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Genesis

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the beginning[a] God[b] created the heavens and the earth.[c] 2 Now the
earth was formless and empty,[d] and darkness was over the surface of
the deep, and the Spirit[e] of God was hovering[f] over the surface of the
waters.
3 Then God said, "Let there be light," and there was light. 4 God saw
the light, that it was good, and God separated between the light and
the darkness. 5 God called the light Day, and the darkness he called
Night. And there was evening and there was morning: day one.[g]
6 Then God said, "Let there be an expanse[h] in the middle of the waters,
and let it separate between waters and waters." 7 So God made the
expanse, and he separated between the waters that were under the
expanse and the waters that were above the expanse. And it was so.[i]
8 God called the expanse Heavens. And there was evening and there
was morning: a second day.
9 Then God said, "Let the waters under the heavens be gathered into
one place,[j] and let the dry land appear." And it was so. 10 God named
the dry ground Earth, and the collected waters he named Seas. God
saw that this was good. 11 Then God said, "Let the earth sprout green
growth: plants that yield seed, and fruit trees that bear fruit according
to their kind, with their seed in it, on the earth." And it was so. 12 The
earth brought forth green growth: plants that yield seed according to
their kind, and trees that bear fruit with their seed in it, according to
their kind. And God saw that it was good. 13 And there was evening
and there was morning: a third day.
14 Then God said, "Let there be lights in the expanse of the heavens to
separate between the day and the night, and let them serve as signs
and for appointed times,[k] and for days and years. 15 Let them be lights
in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth." And it was

so. 16 God made the two great lights: the greater light to rule the day
and the lesser light to rule the night,[l] and also the stars. 17 God placed
them in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth, 18 to rule
over the day and over the night, and to separate between the light
and the darkness. And God saw that it was good. 19 And there was
evening and there was morning: a fourth day.
20 Then God said, "Let the waters swarm with teeming living crea-
tures,[m] and let flying birds soar above the land, beneath the dome of
the sky." 21 So God created the huge sea monsters[n] and all the living
creatures that glide and swarm in the waters, each by its own species,
and every winged bird by its species. God saw that it was good. 22 God
blessed them, saying, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the waters in
the seas, and let the birds multiply on the earth." 23 And there was
evening and there was morning: a fifth day.
24 Then God said, "Let the land produce living creatures by their
species: tame animals, crawling creatures, and wild beasts, each by its
species." And so it happened. 25 God made the wild beasts of the earth
by their species, the tame animals by their species, and everything
that crawls on the soil by its species. God saw that it was good. 26 Then
God said, "Let us make humankind[o] in our image, to be like us. They
will govern the fish in the sea, the birds in the sky, the tame animals,
all the earth,[p] and every creature that crawls along the ground." 27 So
God created humankind in his own image; in the image of God he
created him; male and female he created them.[q] 28 God blessed them,
and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and
bring it under control. Rule over the fish of the sea, over the birds of
the heavens, and over every living thing that creeps on the earth." 29
Then God said, "See, I give you every plant that yields seed, across
the whole face of the earth, and every tree whose fruit holds its seed.
These will be your food. 30 To all the wild animals, to all the birds
in the sky, and to every creature crawling on the earth that has the
breath of life, I give every green plant for food." And so it happened.
31 God saw everything that he had made, and look, it was very good.
And there was evening and there was morning: the sixth day.[r]

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew bereshit. It can also be read as the start of a longer sentence: "When God began to create the heavens and the earth, the earth was formless…" The Septuagint (en archē, "in the beginning") supports the traditional reading kept here.
- b (1:1) Hebrew Elohim. The word is plural in form, but here it takes a singular verb (bara, "he created"), so it names the one God. Elohim is a title, not a personal name; this translation renders it "God" when it refers to the true God, and keeps the personal name Yahweh where the Hebrew has it (see the note on 2:4 and Conventions).
- c (1:1) "The heavens and the earth" pairs two opposites to mean everything that exists.
- d (1:2) Hebrew tohu wabohu, a rhyming pair: "a waste and a void," land not yet shaped or filled. Days 1 to 3 give it shape; days 4 to 6 fill it.
- e (1:2) Hebrew ruach means spirit, wind, or breath. Some render "a wind from God" or "a mighty wind."
- f (1:2) The same verb describes an eagle hovering over its young in Deuteronomy 32:11.
- g (1:5) Literally "one day." Hebrew uses the number one here, not "first." Days 2 to 5 have no article ("a second day"); day 6 has one (see 1:31).
- h (1:6) Hebrew raqia, from a verb meaning to hammer out or spread thin, as with metal. Septuagint stereōma, Latin firmamentum ("firmament"). Also called a vault or dome.
- i (1:7) The Septuagint places "And it was so" at the end of 1:6, and in 1:8 it adds "And God saw that it was good," which the Hebrew lacks for the second day.
- j (1:9) Masoretic Text maqom, "place." A Qumran fragment (4QGen-h) and the Septuagint reflect miqweh, "one gathering," which matches "gathering" in 1:10. The Septuagint also adds: "And the water under the heaven was gathered into its gatherings, and the dry land appeared." A Qumran fragment (4QGen-k) appears to support this added clause in Hebrew.
- k (1:14) Hebrew moadim, the word later used for Israel's appointed festivals. Also translated "seasons."
- l (1:16) The sun and moon are not named. Israel's neighbors worshiped them as gods; here they are lamps that God made and placed.
- m (1:20) Hebrew nefesh chayyah, "living being" or "living soul." The same phrase is used of the first human in 2:7. The Septuagint adds "And it was so" at the end of this verse.
- n (1:21) Hebrew tanninim, used elsewhere of sea monsters and serpents (Psalm 74:13; Isaiah 27:1). Even these are only creatures God made.
- o (1:26) Hebrew adam, here meaning the human race (note "let them rule"). "Us" and "our" have been read as a royal plural, a plural of self-deliberation, God speaking to his heavenly court, or, in Christian reading, a first hint of the Trinity.

- p (1:26) The Syriac Peshitta reads “over all the wild animals of the earth,” which matches the list in 1:25 and may preserve the original wording.
- q (1:27) “Humankind” is again Hebrew adam, the word that later becomes the name Adam. The Hebrew moves from “him” (singular) to “them” (plural): one human race, created male and female. The verse is written as a short three-line poem.
- r (1:31) This is the first day with the definite article in Hebrew (“the sixth day”), marking the high point of the account.

Chapter 2

1 So the heavens and the earth were completed, and everything in them.[a] 2 On the seventh day[b] God brought to an end the work he had been doing, and on the seventh day he ceased[c] from all the work he had been doing. 3 God blessed the seventh day and made it holy, because on it he rested from all his work that God had created and made.[d]

4 This is the account[e] of the heavens and the earth when they were created, on the day that Yahweh[f] God made earth and heavens. 5 No bush of the field had yet appeared on the earth, and no grain of the field had yet sprouted, because Yahweh God had not caused rain to fall on the land, and there was no human[g] to farm the soil. 6 But a mist[h] used to rise from the ground and moisten the entire surface of the soil. 7 Then Yahweh God formed[i] Adam[j] from the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and Adam became a living being.[k]

8 Yahweh God planted a garden eastward, in Eden,[l] and there he set Adam, whom he had formed. 9 From the soil Yahweh God made grow every tree that was lovely in appearance and good to eat, and in the center of the garden stood the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.[m] 10 A river flows out of Eden to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four headwaters. 11 The first is named Pishon. It circles through all the territory of Havilah, a land with gold. 12 The gold of that land is good; bdellium and onyx stone[n] are there. 13 The name of the second river is Gihon. It is the one that winds through the whole land of Cush.[o] 14 The third river is named Tigris;[p] it runs along the east side of Assyria. The fourth is the Euphrates.

15 Yahweh God took Adam and placed him in the garden of Eden to
work it and to keep it.[q] 16 And Yahweh God commanded Adam, saying,
"From every tree of the garden you may freely eat,[r] 17 but from the
tree of the knowledge of good and evil you must not eat, for on the
day that you eat from it you will surely die."[s]
18 Then Yahweh God said, "It is not good for Adam to be alone. I will
make a helper for him who corresponds to him."[t] 19 Now out of the
ground Yahweh God had formed every animal of the field and every
bird of the heavens, and he brought them to Adam to see what he
would call each one. Whatever Adam called each living creature, that
became its name. 20 Adam gave names to all the livestock, to the birds
of the heavens, and to every animal of the field. But for Adam[u] no
helper was found who corresponded to him. 21 So Yahweh God made
Adam fall into a deep sleep, and while he slept, God removed one
of his sides[v] and filled in the flesh where it had been. 22 Yahweh God
built[w] the side that he had taken from Adam into a woman, and he
brought her to Adam. 23 Then Adam said, "This one, at last, is bone
from my bones and flesh from my flesh. This one shall be called
Woman, for from Man this one was taken."[x] 24 That is why a man
leaves his father and his mother and holds fast to his wife, and they
become one flesh.[y] 25 The two of them were naked,[z] Adam and his
wife, and they were not ashamed.

Notes

- a (2:1) Literally "and all their host," that is, their whole array or army: everything that fills the sky and the land.
- b (2:2) The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, and the Syriac read "on the sixth day," probably to avoid any hint that God worked on the seventh day. The Masoretic "seventh" is the harder reading and is kept here; the Hebrew verb can mean "had completed."
- c (2:2) Hebrew shavat, "ceased" or "stopped," the root of the word Sabbath (shabbat). It means stopping work, not recovering from tiredness.
- d (2:3) Literally "which God created to make."
- e (2:4) Hebrew toledot, "generations" or "family history." This is the first of the toledot headings that divide Genesis into its main parts.
- f (2:4) Here the personal name of God, YHWH, appears for the first time. In Exodus 3:14–15 the name is linked with the verb "to be": "I am who I am" (or "I will be what I will be"); many scholars also understand it as "he causes to be." Ancient Jews

stopped saying the name aloud, so its original vowels were not written. "Yahweh" is the pronunciation reconstructed by scholars from early Greek transcriptions and from shortened forms in Hebrew names. The Masoretic Text points the name with the vowels of Adonai ("Lord"), and older English Bibles therefore print "the LORD." Some Dead Sea Scrolls write the name in the older paleo-Hebrew letters as a mark of reverence. The Septuagint usually renders it kyrios, "Lord." See Conventions.

- g (2:5) Hebrew adam, "human," sounds like adamah, "ground." The wordplay runs through chapters 2 and 3: the human (adam) comes from the ground (adamah), works the ground, and returns to it (3:19). English might echo it as "earthling" from "earth."
- h (2:6) Hebrew ed, a rare word. It may mean a spring or an underground stream (compare Akkadian edû, "flood"). The Septuagint reads pēgē, "spring."
- i (2:7) Hebrew yatsar, the word for a potter shaping clay (Jeremiah 18:4–6). This image of God as potter and people as clay vessels gives this translation its name.
- j (2:7) Hebrew ha-adam, literally "the human" or "the man." Adam sounds like adamah, "ground": the human is formed from the ground, works it, and returns to it (2:5; 3:19). Through most of chapters 2–3 the Hebrew has the article ("the human"), and the word is clearly used as a personal name only later (4:25; 5:1–5). This translation writes "Adam" from here on wherever the one man is meant; where adam means the human race (1:26–27; 5:1–2) it is rendered "humankind."
- k (2:7) Hebrew nefesh chayyah, the same phrase used of the animals in 1:20, 24. Older translations: "a living soul."
- l (2:8) Eden probably means "delight" or "abundance." The Septuagint calls the garden paradeisos, a park, from which comes the English word paradise.
- m (2:9) "Good and evil" may be a pair of opposites meaning knowledge of everything, or the claim to decide for oneself what is good and what is evil.
- n (2:12) Bdellium (Hebrew bedolach) is a fragrant tree resin. The stone (Hebrew shoham) is uncertain: onyx, carnelian, and lapis lazuli have all been proposed.
- o (2:13) Cush usually means the land south of Egypt (ancient Nubia). Some scholars connect it here with the Kassites of Mesopotamia.
- p (2:14) Hebrew Hiddeqel is the Tigris; Hebrew Perat is the Euphrates.
- q (2:15) Hebrew avad and shamar. Elsewhere the same pair describes the priests who serve and guard the sanctuary (Numbers 3:7–8), so the garden is pictured as a place of worship as well as work.
- r (2:16) Literally "eating you may eat." Hebrew doubles the verb for emphasis: the permission is generous.
- s (2:17) Literally "dying you will die." The serpent echoes and denies these exact words in 3:4.
- t (2:18) Hebrew ezer kenegdo. Ezer, "helper," is most often used of God helping his people (Exodus 18:4; Psalm 33:20; 121:1–2), so it does not imply lower rank. Kenegdo means "as in front of him": a partner who matches him. The Septuagint and Latin Vulgate read "Let us make."

- u (2:20) Here the Hebrew vowel pointing lacks the article, so even the Masoretic Text may read adam as the personal name Adam (compare 3:17, 21; 4:25). See the note on 2:7.
- v (2:21) Hebrew tsela, which usually means "side" (for example, the side of the tabernacle in Exodus 26:20). Traditionally "rib."
- w (2:22) Literally "built," the verb used for building a house or an altar.
- x (2:23) Hebrew ishshah, "woman," sounds like ish, "man." English "woman" and "man" keep the play. "At last" is literally "this time." The verse is a short poem, the first recorded human words.
- y (2:24) The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, the Syriac, and the Vulgate read "and the two of them will become one flesh." Jesus and Paul quote this longer form (Matthew 19:5; Mark 10:8; Ephesians 5:31).
- z (2:25) Hebrew arummim, "naked," sounds like arum, "crafty," in the very next verse (3:1).

Chapter 3

1 The serpent was more cunning[a] than any wild creature Yahweh God
had made. He said to the woman, "So God has said,[b] 'You are not to
eat from any tree in the garden'?" 2 The woman answered the serpent,
"We are allowed to eat the fruit from the trees in the garden, 3 Only
of the fruit of the tree in the center of the garden God said, 'Do not
eat of it or even touch it, or you will die.'" 4 The serpent said to the
woman, "You will not surely die. 5 God knows that when you eat of
it, your eyes will open, and you will be like God,[c] knowing good and
evil." 6 The woman saw that the tree was good to eat, that it delighted
the eyes, and that it was to be desired for gaining wisdom.[d] So she
took some of its fruit and ate it. She also gave some to her husband,
who was beside her, and he ate it. 7 Then the eyes of both of them
were opened, and they knew that they were naked. So they sewed fig
leaves together and made coverings for themselves.
8 They heard the sound[e] of Yahweh God walking in the garden in
the cool of the day,[f] and Adam and his wife hid themselves from the
presence[g] of Yahweh God among the trees of the garden. 9 But Yahweh
God called out to Adam, "Where are you?" 10 He answered, "I heard
your sound in the garden, and I was afraid because I was naked, so
I hid myself." 11 He said, "Who told you that you were naked? Have
you eaten from the tree that I commanded you not to eat from?" 12

Adam said, “The woman whom you gave to be with me, she gave me
fruit from the tree, and I ate.” 13 Then Yahweh God said to the woman,
“What have you done?” The woman answered, “The serpent misled
me,[h] and I ate.”
14 Yahweh God said to the serpent, “Since you have done this, you
are cursed beyond all cattle and beyond every wild creature. You will
go on your belly and eat dust as long as you live. 15 I will set enmity
between you and the woman, and between your seed[i] and her seed.
He will crush[j] your head, and you will bruise his heel.”
16 To the woman he said, “I will multiply your suffering in pregnancy;[k]
you will bear children in pain. Your longing[l] will be toward your
husband, and he will have authority over you.”
17 And to Adam[m] he said, “You heeded your wife’s voice and ate from
the tree I forbade you, when I said, ‘Do not eat of it.’ So the ground is
cursed on your account. With painful toil[n] you will draw your food
from it as long as you live. 18 Thorns and thistles it will grow for you,
and you will eat the plants of the field. 19 With sweat on your face[o]
you will eat bread until you go back to the ground, since from it you
were taken. Dust is what you are, and to dust you will go back.”
20 Adam named his wife Eve,[p] because she became the mother of all
the living. 21 Yahweh God made garments of skin for Adam and for
his wife, and he clothed them.
22 Then Yahweh God said, “Look, Adam has become like one of us,
knowing good and evil. And now, so that he does not reach out his
hand and take also from the tree of life, and eat, and live forever…”[q]
23 So Yahweh God sent him out from the garden of Eden to work the
ground from which he had been taken. 24 He drove out Adam,[r] and on
the east side of the garden of Eden he stationed the cherubim[s] and
the flame of a sword that turned every way,[t] to guard the way to the
tree of life.

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew arum, “crafty” or “shrewd.” In Proverbs the word is a virtue (“prudent”). It plays on arummim, “naked,” in 2:25.
- b (3:1) Hebrew af ki, literally “Indeed, that God said…?” The serpent’s question twists God’s generous “every tree” (2:16) into “not any tree.”

- c (3:5) Hebrew elohim can mean “God,” “gods,” or “divine beings.” The word for “knowing” is plural, so “like gods” is possible; the Septuagint reads “like gods.”
- d (3:6) Hebrew lehaskil, “to make wise” or “to gain insight.” It may also mean “to look at”; the Septuagint has “beautiful to contemplate.”
- e (3:8) Hebrew qol, “sound” or “voice”; also in 3:10, 17.
- f (3:8) Thought for thought. Literally “at the wind (ruach) of the day,” most likely the breezy time of late afternoon or evening.
- g (3:8) Literally “from the face of.”
- h (3:13) Hebrew hishshiani, “led me astray” or “tricked me.” Paul alludes to this in 2 Corinthians 11:3 and 1 Timothy 2:14.
- i (3:15) Literally “seed.” The word is singular and can mean many descendants or one descendant. Hebrew then says “he” (hu). The Septuagint also uses “he” (autos), even though “seed” is a neuter word in Greek, which suggests early readers saw one person here. From the second century (Irenaeus) Christians have read this verse as the first announcement of the gospel.
- j (3:15) Hebrew shuf, a rare verb used in both halves of the line; it may mean “crush,” “bruise,” or “strike.” The Septuagint has “watch for”; the Vulgate has “crush.”
- k (3:16) Thought for thought. Literally “your pain and your conception,” two nouns joined to express one idea (pain connected with pregnancy).
- l (3:16) Hebrew teshuqah, used again in 4:7 (sin’s desire for Cain) and in Song of Songs 7:10. The Septuagint reads “your turning” (apostrophē), as if from Hebrew teshuvah.
- m (3:17) Here the Hebrew vowel pointing lacks the article, so the Masoretic Text itself reads the personal name Adam (see the notes on 2:7 and 2:20).
- n (3:17) Hebrew itstsavon, from the same root as the woman’s “pain” in 3:16. Man and woman share the same word of grief.
- o (3:19) Literally “of your nostrils” or “of your face.”
- p (3:20) Hebrew Chavvah, which sounds like chai, “living.”
- q (3:22) The Hebrew sentence breaks off without finishing. Verse 23 supplies the action.
- r (3:24) The Septuagint reads: “He drove out Adam and settled him opposite the garden of delight, and stationed the cherubim…”
- s (3:24) Cherubim is the Hebrew plural of cherub: winged guardian beings, later pictured over the ark of the covenant (Exodus 25:18–22).
- t (3:24) Literally “the flame of the sword that turns itself about,” that is, a flashing, whirling blade.

Chapter 4

1 Adam knew[a] Eve his wife. She conceived and bore Cain,[b] and she said, “With Yahweh’s help I have gained a man.”[c] 2 She later bore his brother Abel.[d] Abel tended flocks, while Cain farmed the soil.

3 In the course of time[e] Cain brought an offering to Yahweh from
the fruit of the ground. 4 And Abel, for his part, brought some of the
firstborn of his flock and some of their fat portions. Yahweh looked
with favor on Abel and on his offering, 5 but on Cain and on his
offering he did not look with favor. So Cain became very angry, and
his face fell. 6 Yahweh asked Cain, "Why are you so angry? Why is
your face cast down? 7 Do right, and will you not be lifted up?[f] But if
you do not do right, sin lies crouching at your door.[g] It longs to have
you, but you are to master it." 8 Cain spoke to Abel his brother.[h] And
when they were in the field, Cain rose up against Abel his brother
and killed him.
9 Yahweh asked Cain, "Where is your brother Abel?" "I have no idea,"
he replied. "Is it my job to guard my brother?"[i] 10 Yahweh said, "What
have you done? Hear it: the blood[j] of your brother is crying to me out
of the soil. 11 So now you are under a curse, driven from the soil that
opened wide to take in your brother's blood from your hand. 12 When
you till the soil, it will not yield its strength to you again. You will be
a drifter and a wanderer[k] on the earth." 13 Cain said to Yahweh, "My
punishment[l] is greater than I can bear. 14 Today you are driving me off
the face of the land, and I must hide from your face. I will drift and
wander on the earth, and anyone who comes upon me will kill me."
15 But Yahweh said to him, "Therefore[m] anyone who kills Cain will
suffer sevenfold vengeance." Then Yahweh set a sign[n] upon Cain, so
that none who met him would strike him dead. 16 Cain left Yahweh's
presence and made his home in the land of Nod,[o] east of Eden.
17 Cain knew his wife, and she conceived and bore Enoch.[p] Cain then
built a city and called it Enoch, after his son. 18 Enoch had a son, Irad.
Irad became the father of Mehujael, Mehujael of Methushael, and
Methushael of Lamech. 19 Lamech took two wives for himself. The
name of the one was Adah, and the name of the other was Zillah. 20
Adah bore Jabal, the ancestor of those who dwell in tents and raise
herds. 21 His brother's name was Jubal. He was the father of all who
play the lyre and the pipe.[q] 22 Zillah also gave birth to Tubal-cain, who
forged all kinds of tools of bronze and iron.[r] The sister of Tubal-cain
was Naamah.

23 Lamech said to his wives:[s] “Adah and Zillah, hear me; wives of
Lamech, give heed to my words. I killed a man for bruising me, a
youth for a blow he gave me. 24 If sevenfold vengeance is for Cain, for
Lamech it is seventy-sevenfold.”[t]
25 Once more Adam knew his wife. She bore a son and called him Seth,[u]
“because,” she said, “God has granted me another child in Abel’s
place, since Cain killed him.” 26 Seth too had a son, whom he called
Enosh.[v] It was then that people first called on the name of Yahweh.[w]

Notes

- a (4:1) Hebrew yada, “knew,” a common idiom for sexual union.
- b (4:1) Cain (Hebrew Qayin) sounds like qaniti, “I have gained.” The name itself may also mean “metalworker” (compare Tubal-cain, 4:22).
- c (4:1) Literally “with Yahweh” (et-YHWH). The Septuagint reads “through God.” Other proposals: “I have created a man, as Yahweh did” or “I have gained a man, Yahweh.”
- d (4:2) Abel (Hebrew Hevel) means “breath” or “vapor,” the word translated “meaningless” or “vanity” in Ecclesiastes. It hints at his brief life.
- e (4:3) Literally “at the end of days.”
- f (4:7) Hebrew seet, literally “a lifting.” It may mean acceptance, forgiveness (sin “lifted”), or a lifted face, the opposite of the fallen face in 4:5–6. This is one of the hardest verses in Genesis.
- g (4:7) “Crouching” (rovets) pictures an animal lying in wait; it may echo the Akkadian rabisu, a demon thought to lurk at doorways. The next words, “its desire is for you, but you must rule over it,” repeat the wording of 3:16.
- h (4:8) Literally “Cain said to Abel his brother,” but the Masoretic Text gives no words, and some Hebrew manuscripts leave a gap here. The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint (“into the plain”), the Syriac, and the Vulgate add: “Let us go out to the field.” We keep the shorter Hebrew and render “said to” as “spoke to.”
- i (4:9) Hebrew shomer, from the same verb as “keep” in 2:15.
- j (4:10) “Blood” is plural in Hebrew (“bloods”). Jewish tradition (Mishnah Sanhedrin 4:5) took it to include the descendants Abel never had.
- k (4:12) Thought for thought. Hebrew na wanad, a rhyming pair meaning “wandering and drifting,” like tohu wabohu in 1:2. Nad anticipates the land of Nod (4:16). The Septuagint reads “groaning and trembling.”
- l (4:13) Hebrew avon means both guilt and its punishment. The verse can also be read, “My guilt is too great to be forgiven” (literally “to be lifted,” the same verb as in 4:7). The Septuagint reads “My crime is too great for me to be forgiven.”
- m (4:15) Hebrew lakhen, “therefore.” The Septuagint, the Syriac, and the Vulgate read “Not so!” (lo khen).

- n (4:15) Hebrew ot, the same word used for the "signs" in the sky (1:14) and the rainbow (9:12). Its nature is not described; it is a mark of protection, not of shame.
- o (4:16) Nod means "wandering," from the same root as "wanderer" in 4:12, 14.
- p (4:17) Enoch (Hebrew Chanokh) may mean "dedicated." This is Cain's son, not the Enoch of 5:18–24. The Hebrew can also be read to mean that Enoch built the city and named it after his own son.
- q (4:21) Hebrew kinnor, a stringed instrument, and ugav, probably a flute or pipe.
- r (4:22) Thought for thought. Literally "a sharpener of every cutting tool of bronze and iron." Hebrew nechoshet means copper or bronze.
- s (4:23) Lamech's words (4:23–24) are the first poem after Eden, a boast of revenge. The verbs can also be read as a threat: "I will kill a man for wounding me."
- t (4:24) Or "seventy times seven." Jesus seems to reverse this boast when he tells Peter to forgive "seventy-seven times" (Matthew 18:22).
- u (4:25) Seth (Hebrew Shet) sounds like shat, "he has appointed" or "granted."
- v (4:26) Enosh means "human" or "mortal," a synonym of adam (Psalm 8:4).
- w (4:26) Literally "then it was begun to call on the name of Yahweh." The Septuagint reads "he hoped to call on the name of the Lord God," reading the Hebrew verb differently.

Chapter 5

1 This is the book of the generations[a] of Adam. On the day that God created humankind,[b] he made him in the likeness of God. 2 He made them male and female. He blessed them, and on the day of their creation he gave them the name Humankind.[c]

3 At 130 years of age[d] Adam fathered a son like himself, in his own image, and called him Seth.[e] 4 After Seth's birth Adam lived 800 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 5 Adam's life came to 930 years in all, and then he died.

6 At 105 years of age Seth fathered Enosh. 7 After Enosh's birth Seth lived 807 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 8 Seth's life came to 912 years in all, and then he died.

9 At 90 years of age Enosh fathered Kenan.[f] 10 After Kenan's birth Enosh lived 815 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 11 Enosh's life came to 905 years in all, and then he died.

12 At 70 years of age Kenan fathered Mahalalel.[g] 13 After Mahalalel's birth Kenan lived 840 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 14 Kenan's life came to 910 years in all, and then he died.

15 At 65 years of age Mahalalel fathered Jared.[h] 16 After Jared's birth
Mahalalel lived 830 more years, and other sons and daughters were
born to him. 17 Mahalalel's life came to 895 years in all, and then he
died.
18 At 162 years of age Jared fathered Enoch. 19 After Enoch's birth Jared
lived 800 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him.
20 Jared's life came to 962 years in all, and then he died.
21 At 65 years of age Enoch fathered Methuselah.[i] 22 Enoch walked with
God[j] after he fathered Methuselah 300 years, and he fathered sons
and daughters. 23 So all the days of Enoch were 365 years.[k] 24 Enoch
walked with God, and then he was no more, for God took him.[l]
25 At 187 years of age Methuselah fathered Lamech. 26 After Lamech's
birth Methuselah lived 782 more years, and other sons and daughters
were born to him. 27 Methuselah's life came to 969 years in all, and
then he died.[m]
28 At 182 years of age Lamech fathered a son. 29 He named him Noah,
saying, "This one will comfort us[n] in our work and in the painful
toil of our hands, from the ground that Yahweh has cursed." 30 After
Noah's birth Lamech lived 595 more years, and other sons and
daughters were born to him. 31 Lamech's life came to 777 years in all,
and then he died.
32 After Noah had reached 500 years of age, he fathered Shem, Ham,
and Japheth.[o]

Notes

- a (5:1) Hebrew sefer toledot, "the written record of the family line." It is the second toledot heading (see 2:4). Matthew 1:1 opens with the same phrase in Greek.
- b (5:1) Hebrew adam. In 5:1–2 the word looks back to 1:26–28 and means humankind; from 5:3 on it is the personal name Adam.
- c (5:2) Hebrew adam, the same word as the name Adam in 5:1, 3. Here it names the human race, male and female (compare 1:26–27).
- d (5:3) Hebrew writes numbers in words, often smaller units first (literally "thirty and a hundred years"). We use figures for clarity throughout the genealogies.
- e (5:3) The ages in Genesis 5 differ among the witnesses; no Dead Sea Scroll preserves them. The Septuagint adds 100 years to the age at fatherhood of Adam, Seth, Enosh, Kenan, Mahalalel, and Enoch (230, 205, 190, 170, 165, 165) and subtracts 100 from the years that follow, so the life spans stay the same. It gives Methuselah 167 years at fatherhood and 802 after (Codex Alexandrinus: 187 and 782), and Lamech

188, 565, and 753 in all. The Samaritan Pentateuch agrees with the Masoretic Text except for Jared (62, 785, 847 in all), Methuselah (67, 653, 720), and Lamech (53, 600, 653). From creation to the flood these give 1,656 years (Masoretic), 1,307 (Samaritan), and 2,242 (Septuagint).

- f (5:9) Kenan (Hebrew Qenan) is related to the name Cain. Several names in this line resemble names in Cain's line (4:17–18): Enoch, Lamech, Irad/Jared, Methushael/Methuselah.
- g (5:12) Mahalalel means "praise of God."
- h (5:15) Jared probably means "descent."
- i (5:21) Methuselah probably means "man of the spear" or "man of Shelah."
- j (5:22) Literally "walked about with God," a picture of close, daily fellowship, said also of Noah (6:9). The Septuagint reads "was well-pleasing to God," the wording quoted in Hebrews 11:5.
- k (5:23) 365, the number of days in a solar year. The book of 1 Enoch, quoted in Jude 14–15, develops traditions about Enoch, including a solar calendar.
- l (5:24) Literally "and he was not." "Took" (laqach) is the verb used when Elijah is taken up (2 Kings 2:3, 10). The Septuagint reads "he was not found, because God transferred him" (Hebrews 11:5).
- m (5:27) By the Masoretic numbers Methuselah dies in the year of the flood. By the main Septuagint numbers he would outlive the flood by 14 years, an early difficulty that the reading of Codex Alexandrinus (187 years) avoids.
- n (5:29) Noah (Hebrew Noach) sounds like nuach, "rest," and is linked here with nacham, "comfort." The Septuagint reads "will give us rest." "Painful toil" (itst-savon) and the cursed ground look back to 3:17.
- o (5:32) Shem means "name." Ham may mean "hot" or "warm." Japheth is played on in 9:27 ("enlarge"). The order may not be by age (see 9:24; 10:21).

Chapter 6

1 When humankind began to multiply on the face of the ground,
and daughters were born to them, 2 the sons of God[a] saw that the
daughters of humankind were beautiful, and they took as wives any
of them they chose. 3 Then Yahweh said, "My Spirit will not remain[b]
in humankind forever, because they are flesh.[c] Their days will be
120 years."[d] 4 The Nephilim[e] were on the earth in those days, and
also afterward, when the sons of God went in to the daughters of
humankind and they bore children to them. These were the mighty
men[f] of old, the men of renown.[g]
5 Yahweh saw how great human wickedness had grown on the earth,
and that every plan[h] formed by their hearts' thoughts was nothing
but evil, all day long. 6 Yahweh was sorry[i] he had made human beings

on the earth, and grief pierced[j] his heart. 7 Yahweh said, "I will blot humankind, whom I created, off the surface of the ground, together with the animals, the crawling creatures, and the birds of the sky, for I am sorry that I made them." 8 But Noah found favor[k] in the eyes of Yahweh.

9 This is the account of Noah. Noah was a righteous man, blameless[l] among the people of his time.[m] Noah walked with God. 10 Noah fathered three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

11 In God's sight the earth had gone to ruin,[n] and it was full of violence.[o] 12 God looked at the earth, and it was corrupt, for all flesh had corrupted its way on the earth.

13 God said to Noah, "The end of all living creatures has come before me,[p] for through them the earth is full of violence. I am about to bring them to ruin, and the earth with them. 14 Make yourself an ark[q] of gopher wood.[r] Make rooms in the ark, and coat it inside and outside with pitch.[s] 15 This is how you are to build it: make it about 450 feet in length, 75 feet in breadth, and 45 feet in height.[t] 16 Make a roof[u] for the ark and finish it off about eighteen inches from the top. Set a door in its side, and build it with three decks, lower, middle, and upper. 17 For my part, I am going to bring the flood[v] of waters on the earth, to destroy all flesh in which there is the breath of life, from under the heavens. Everything that is on the earth will perish.

18 But I will establish my covenant[w] with you, and you will go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife and your sons' wives with you. 19 From every living creature, from all flesh, you must bring a pair into the ark so that they may survive with you, one male and one female. 20 From the birds by their species, from the tame animals by their species, and from every creature that crawls on the soil by its species, a pair will come to you so that they may be kept alive. 21 And you, take with you some of every kind of food that is eaten, and store it up; it will be food for you and for them." 22 Noah did this. He did all that God commanded him; so he did.

Notes

- a (6:2) Hebrew bene ha-elohim. There are three main readings. (1) Heavenly beings, as the same phrase means in Job 1:6, 2:1, and 38:7. This is the oldest known Jewish

reading, told at length in 1 Enoch 6–16 (the Watchers) and Jubilees 5, and echoed in Jude 6 and 2 Peter 2:4; Codex Alexandrinus of the Septuagint reads "angels of God." (2) Men of Seth's godly line marrying women of Cain's line, a view taught by Julius Africanus and Augustine. (3) Kings or powerful men, as in some rabbinic interpretation and Targum Onqelos ("sons of the great ones").

- b (6:3) Hebrew yadon, a verb found only here; its meaning is uncertain. The Septuagint and Vulgate read "remain." Others render "strive with" or "contend with."
- c (6:3) Hebrew beshaggam, "because also" (they are flesh). It may also be read "in their going astray."
- d (6:3) Either a limit on the human life span or the time left before the flood.
- e (6:4) Nephilim is left untranslated. It may come from naphal, "fall," so "fallen ones" or "those who fall upon others." The Septuagint reads gigantes, "giants." The only other use is Numbers 13:33. The Hebrew does not clearly say the Nephilim were the children of these unions; they were already there "in those days."
- f (6:4) Hebrew gibborim, "warriors" or "heroes."
- g (6:4) Literally "men of the name." Compare the builders who want to make a "name" for themselves in 11:4.
- h (6:5) Hebrew yetser, from yatsar, "to form" (2:7): what the heart shapes and plans. Later Jewish teaching speaks of the yetser ha-ra, the "evil inclination."
- i (6:6) Hebrew nacham, which can mean "regret," "be sorry," "change one's mind," or "be comforted." It plays on Noah's name (5:29). Scripture uses human language to express God's grief while also teaching that God does not change his mind as humans do (Numbers 23:19).
- j (6:6) From the same root as "pain" and "painful toil" in 3:16–17 and 5:29. God shares the grief that sin brought on people.
- k (6:8) Hebrew chen, "favor" or "grace." Its consonants (ch-n) are those of Noah's name (n-ch) reversed.
- l (6:9) Hebrew tamim, "whole, complete, sound," the word used for sacrificial animals without defect. It does not mean sinless (see 9:21).
- m (6:9) Literally "in his generations."
- n (6:11) Hebrew shachat, "spoiled, ruined." The same verb is translated "destroy" in 6:13, 17: God brings to ruin what people had already ruined.
- o (6:11) Hebrew chamas, violence or brutal wrongdoing.
- p (6:13) Thought for thought. Literally "The end of all flesh has come before me."
- q (6:14) Hebrew tevah, a box or chest. The only other use is the basket in which the baby Moses was saved (Exodus 2:3–5).
- r (6:14) The wood is unknown, perhaps cypress or another resinous wood, so the Hebrew word is kept. The Septuagint reads "squared timber."
- s (6:14) Hebrew kofer, from kafar, "to cover," the same root later used for atonement.
- t (6:15) Hebrew "300 cubits the length of the ark, 50 cubits its width, and 30 cubits its height." A cubit is the length of a forearm; counting it as about 18 inches (45 centimeters), the ark was about 450 by 75 by 45 feet (135 by 22.5 by 13.5 meters).

Cubit standards varied; a longer cubit of about 20.5 inches (52 centimeters) would make the ark somewhat larger.

- u (6:16) Hebrew tsohar, found only here. It may mean "roof" or an opening for light (compare tsohorayim, "noon"). "About eighteen inches" is literally "to a cubit," counting a cubit as about 18 inches (45 centimeters); standards varied.
- v (6:17) Hebrew mabbul, used almost only of this flood (compare Psalm 29:10).
- w (6:18) Hebrew berit, the first use of "covenant" in the Bible. The promise is fulfilled in 9:8–17.

Chapter 7

1 Yahweh told Noah, "Go into the ark, you and your whole household,
because in this generation I have found you righteous in my sight.
2 From every clean animal take seven pairs,[a] each a male with his
mate. From the animals that are not clean take one pair, a male
with his mate. 3 Take also seven pairs of the birds of the sky,[b] males
and females, so that their kind may live on over the whole earth. 4
Seven days from now I will make it rain upon the earth for forty
days and forty nights, and I will wipe from the surface of the ground
every living thing[c] I have made." 5 And Noah did all that Yahweh
commanded him.
6 Noah was 600 years old when the flood of waters came on the earth. 7
Noah went into the ark, and his sons and his wife and his sons' wives
with him, to escape the waters of the flood. 8 Of the clean animals and
of the animals that are not clean, of the birds, and of everything that
creeps on the ground, 9 they came to Noah in the ark in pairs, a male
and a female, just as God had instructed Noah. 10 After the seven days
the waters of the flood came on the earth.
11 In the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month (in
April–May), on the seventeenth day of the month,[d] on that day all
the springs of the great deep burst open, and the floodgates[e] of the
heavens were opened. 12 And the rain fell on the earth forty days
and forty nights. 13 On that very day Noah and his sons Shem, Ham,
and Japheth, and Noah's wife and the three wives of his sons with
them, went into the ark, 14 they and every wild animal according to
its kind, every kind of livestock according to its kind, every creeping
thing that creeps on the earth according to its kind, and every bird

according to its kind, every winged creature.[f] 15 They came to Noah
and entered the ark in pairs, from every creature that had the breath
of life. 16 The animals that entered were a male and a female from
every kind of flesh, as God had instructed him. Then Yahweh closed
the door behind him.[g]
17 The flood lasted forty days on the earth.[h] The water rose and lifted
the ark, so that it floated high over the ground. 18 The waters prevailed[i]
and increased greatly on the earth, and the ark floated on the face
of the waters. 19 The waters prevailed more and more on the earth,
and all the high mountains under the whole heavens were covered. 20
The waters rose about 22 feet above them,[j] and the mountains were
covered. 21 All flesh that moved on the earth perished: birds, livestock,
wild animals, every swarming creature that swarms on the earth, and
every human being. 22 Every creature on dry land with the spirit of
life's breath in its nostrils[k] died. 23 Every living thing on the face of
the land was blotted out, human and beast, creeping things and birds
of the sky. They were blotted out from the earth. Noah alone was left,
with those who were with him in the ark. 24 The waters held sway
over the earth for 150 days.[l]

Notes

- a (7:2) Literally "seven seven," which may mean seven pairs or seven animals (three pairs and one more, perhaps for the sacrifice in 8:20). The Septuagint reads "sevens." The distinction between clean and unclean animals looks ahead to Leviticus 11.
- b (7:3) The Septuagint adds "of the clean birds" and continues, "and of all the birds that are not clean, pairs, male and female."
- c (7:4) Hebrew yequm, a rare word: "everything that stands" or "everything that exists."
- d (7:11) Hebrew "in the second month." This translation counts the months from the spring new year (Nisan, also called Abib, in March–April), as Exodus 12:2 does for Israel's festival year, so the second month falls in April–May. The flood account does not say which calendar it follows, and some scholars, like some ancient Jewish interpreters, count from the autumn new year instead, which would put this date in October–November. Hebrew months are lunar, so every modern equivalent is approximate. The Septuagint reads "on the twenty-seventh day." It also gives the twenty-seventh day in 8:4 and 8:14, so that in the Greek the flood lasts exactly one year.

- e (7:11) Hebrew arubbot, “windows” or “lattices,” picturing the sky as a vault with openings (compare 1:6–8).
- f (7:14) Literally “every bird, every wing.”
- g (7:16) The verse moves from “God” (Elohim) to “Yahweh” (YHWH). Scholars have connected such changes with different sources, and readers have long noted the personal care shown: Yahweh himself closes the door.
- h (7:17) The Septuagint reads “forty days and forty nights.”
- i (7:18) Hebrew gavar, “grew strong” or “overpowered,” repeated four times (7:18, 19, 20, 24).
- j (7:20) Hebrew “fifteen cubits upward,” about 22 feet (7 meters), counting a cubit as about 18 inches (45 centimeters); standards varied. Either above the peaks, or half the ark’s height, so that the ark could float clear of them.
- k (7:22) Literally “in whose nostrils was the breath of the spirit of life,” joining the wording of 2:7 and 6:17.
- l (7:24) Five months of 30 days, from the seventeenth day of the second month (7:11) to the seventeenth day of the seventh month (8:4).

Chapter 8

1 But God remembered[a] Noah, together with every wild animal and
every tame animal that was with him in the ark. God caused a wind[b]
to sweep over the land, and the flood receded. 2 The springs of the
deep and the floodgates of the heavens were closed, and the rain from
the heavens was held back. 3 The waters steadily receded[c] from the
earth, and at the end of 150 days the waters had gone down. 4 In the
seventh month (in September–October), on the month’s seventeenth
day,[d] the ark settled[e] on the mountains of Ararat.[f] 5 The waters
continued to go down until the tenth month. In the tenth month (in
December–January), on the first day of the month,[g] the tops of the
mountains became visible.
6 At the end of forty days Noah opened the window of the ark that
he had made, 7 and he sent out the raven. It went out and kept going
back and forth[h] until the waters had dried up from the earth. 8 Then
he sent out the dove from him, to see whether the waters had gone
down from the face of the ground. 9 But the dove could find no place
to rest[i] its foot, since water still covered the face of the whole earth,
and it came back to him in the ark. He put out his hand, caught it, and
took it back into the ark with him. 10 He let seven more days go by
and sent the dove out from the ark once again. 11 The dove came back

to him in the evening, and in its beak was a freshly plucked olive leaf. So Noah knew that the waters had gone down from the earth. 12 He waited seven more days and released the dove, and this time she did not come back to him.

13 In the six hundred and first year,[j] in the first month (in March–April),[k] on the first day of the month, the waters had dried from the earth. Noah removed the covering of the ark and looked, and the face of the ground was dry. 14 In the second month (in April–May), on the twenty-seventh day of the month, the earth was fully dry.[l]

15 Then God spoke to Noah, saying, 16 "Leave the ark, you and your wife, your sons and their wives with you. 17 Bring out with you every living thing that is with you, of all flesh: birds, livestock, and every creeping thing that creeps on the earth, so that they may swarm on the earth and be fruitful and multiply on the earth." 18 So Noah went out, and his sons and his wife and his sons' wives with him. 19 All the animals, all the creeping things, and all the birds, every creature that moves on the earth, came out of the ark, family by family.

20 Then Noah built an altar to Yahweh, and he took some of every clean animal and of every clean bird and offered burnt offerings on the altar. 21 Yahweh smelled the soothing aroma,[m] and Yahweh said in his heart, "Never again will I curse the ground on account of humankind, though the human heart forms evil from youth on.[n] Never again will I strike down every living thing as I have done. 22 As long as the earth remains,[o] sowing and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night will not cease."

Notes

- a (8:1) Hebrew zakar. In the Bible, God "remembering" means acting on someone's behalf, not recalling what was forgotten (compare Exodus 2:24). The verse is the turning point of the flood account.
- b (8:1) Hebrew ruach, as in 1:2. The flood account echoes creation: wind over the waters, dry land appearing, and living things told to be fruitful (8:17).
- c (8:3) Literally "going and returning."
- d (8:4) Hebrew "in the seventh month": September–October on the spring-start reckoning used in this translation (see the note on 7:11); on an autumn-start reckoning, March–April. The Septuagint reads "twenty-seventh day" (see 7:11).
- e (8:4) Hebrew wattanach, from nuach, "rest," the word behind Noah's name (5:29).

- f (8:4) Ararat is a region (Assyrian Urartu) in what is now eastern Turkey and Armenia. The text says "mountains," not a single peak.
- g (8:5) Hebrew "in the tenth month": December–January on the spring-start reckoning used in this translation (see the note on 7:11); on an autumn-start reckoning, June–July.
- h (8:7) Literally "going out and returning." The Septuagint and Vulgate read that the raven "did not return."
- i (8:9) Hebrew manoach, again from nuach, "rest."
- j (8:13) The Septuagint reads "in the six hundred and first year of the life of Noah," matching 7:11.
- k (8:13) Hebrew "in the first month": March–April on the spring-start reckoning (see the note on 7:11); on an autumn-start reckoning, September–October.
- l (8:14) Hebrew "in the second month": April–May on the spring-start reckoning (see the note on 7:11). In the Masoretic Text the flood lasts from 2/17 of Noah's 600th year to 2/27 of his 601st: a lunar year of 354 days plus 11 days, which equals a solar year of 365 days. In the Septuagint (2/27 to 2/27) it lasts exactly one year.
- m (8:21) Hebrew reach ha-nichoach, "the restful (or soothing) aroma," another play on Noah's name (nuach, "rest").
- n (8:21) Or "for the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth." The same diagnosis as 6:5 now leads to mercy rather than judgment.
- o (8:22) Literally "all the days of the earth." The verse is a short poem of pairs.

Chapter 9

1 God blessed Noah and his sons, and said to them, "Be fruitful and
multiply, and fill the earth. 2 Every animal on earth will fear you and
be terrified of you, as will every bird of the sky, all that crawls on the
ground, and every fish of the sea. They are placed in your power. 3
Every moving thing that lives will be food for you. As I gave you the
green plants, I now give you everything. 4 But you must not eat flesh
with its life, that is, its blood.[a] 5 For your lifeblood, too, I will demand
an accounting.[b] I will demand it of every beast and of humankind;
of each one I will demand the life of the fellow human he takes.[c] 6
Whoever sheds the blood of a human, by a human[d] his blood will be
shed, for in the image of God he made humankind. 7 As for you, be
fruitful and multiply; swarm on the earth and multiply on it."[e]
8 Then God said to Noah and to his sons with him, 9 "As for me, I
am establishing my covenant with you and with your offspring after
you, 10 and with every living creature that is with you: the birds, the
livestock, and every animal of the earth with you, all that came out

of the ark, every animal of the earth. 11 I establish my covenant with
you: never again will a flood cut off all flesh, and never again will a
flood devastate the earth."
12 God said, "This is the sign of the covenant that I am setting
between myself and you, and every living creature with you, for all
the generations that follow: 13 I have set my bow[f] in the cloud, and it
will be the sign of the covenant between me and the earth. 14 When
I gather clouds above the earth and the bow appears among them, 15
I will remember the covenant between myself and you and all living
creatures of every kind of flesh. Never again will the waters become a
flood that destroys all flesh. 16 When the bow is in the cloud, I will look
at it and remember the everlasting covenant[g] between God and every
living creature of all flesh that is on the earth." 17 God said to Noah,
"This is the sign of the covenant that I have established between me
and all flesh that is on the earth."
18 The sons of Noah who left the ark were Shem, Ham, and Japheth.
Ham was the father of Canaan. 19 These three were the sons of Noah,
and from these the whole earth was populated.[h]
20 Noah, a farmer, began by planting a vineyard.[i] 21 Drinking of
its wine, he grew drunk and lay exposed within his tent. 22 Ham,
Canaan's father, looked on his father's nakedness[j] and went out and
told his two brothers. 23 Then Shem and Japheth took a cloak, laid
it on both their shoulders, walked in backward, and covered their
father's nakedness. Their faces were turned away, and they did not
see their father's nakedness. 24 When Noah awoke from his wine and
learned what his youngest son[k] had done to him, 25 he said, "Cursed be
Canaan![l] A servant of servants[m] he will be to his brothers." 26 He also
said, "Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Shem![n] And let Canaan be his
servant. 27 May God enlarge Japheth,[o] and may he dwell in the tents
of Shem,[p] and let Canaan be his servant."
28 Noah lived after the flood 350 years. 29 Noah's life came to 950 years
in all, and then he died.

Notes

- a (9:4) Literally "flesh with its life (nefesh), its blood." Blood stands for life, which belongs to God (Leviticus 17:11, 14; compare Acts 15:20).

- b (9:5) Hebrew darash, “seek” or “demand.”
- c (9:5) Literally “from the hand of each man, his brother, I will require the life of the human.”
- d (9:6) The Hebrew is a six-word mirror: shofekh dam ha-adam ba-adam damo yishshafekh, “sheds / blood / of the human // by the human / his blood / will be shed.” “By a human” may also mean “in exchange for the human”; the Septuagint reads “in return for his blood.” The reason given looks back to 1:27.
- e (9:7) The Septuagint reads “fill the earth and rule over it,” and some scholars suggest the second Hebrew “multiply” (urevu) was originally “rule” (uredu), as in 1:28.
- f (9:13) Hebrew qeshet, the ordinary word for a war bow. The image may be of God hanging up his weapon.
- g (9:16) Hebrew berit olam, “everlasting covenant” (compare Isaiah 24:5).
- h (9:19) Literally “was spread out” (nafats), looking ahead to the scattering in 10:32 and 11:8–9.
- i (9:20) Thought for thought. Literally “Noah, the man of the ground, began and planted a vineyard.” “Man of the ground” (adamah) recalls 2:5, 15 and 5:29.
- j (9:22) What Ham did is debated. Some read it as more than looking, since “uncovering the nakedness” of a father is a sexual idiom in Leviticus 18:7–8; others take it as a public act of shame toward his father.
- k (9:24) Hebrew qatan, “small,” here “younger” or “youngest.” Ham is usually listed second (5:32; 10:1).
- l (9:25) The curse falls on Canaan, not on Ham, and looks ahead to Israel’s later conflict with the Canaanites. This verse was misused for centuries to defend slavery and racism. The text names only Canaan, not Ham’s other descendants (Cush, Egypt, Put; 10:6), and says nothing about skin color or race.
- m (9:25) A Hebrew superlative: “the lowest of servants.”
- n (9:26) Instead of blessing Shem directly, Noah blesses Shem’s God. Shem means “name,” and the God of Shem is Yahweh, who will give Abram a great name (12:2).
- o (9:27) Hebrew yaft, “may he enlarge,” sounds like Yefet, Japheth. The Septuagint reads “make room for.”
- p (9:27) “He” may be Japheth, or God dwelling among the descendants of Shem (so the Targums).

Chapter 10

1 This is the account of the sons of Noah: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.
Sons were born to them after the flood.
2 The sons of Japheth:[a] Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech,
and Tiras. 3 The sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz, Riphath, and Togarmah.
4 The sons of Javan: Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, and Dodanim.[b] 5 From

these the coastland peoples[c] spread out in their lands, each with its own language, by their clans, in their nations.

6 The sons of Ham: Cush, Mizraim,[d] Put, and Canaan. 7 The sons of Cush: Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Raamah, and Sabteca. The sons of Raamah: Sheba and Dedan. 8 Cush fathered Nimrod.[e] He was the first on the earth to become a mighty warrior. 9 He was a mighty hunter before Yahweh.[f] That is why it is said, "Like Nimrod, a mighty hunter before Yahweh." 10 The beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, Accad, and Calneh,[g] in the land of Shinar.[h] 11 From that land he went out to Assyria[i] and built Nineveh, Rehoboth-ir,[j] Calah, 12 and Resen, which lies between Nineveh and Calah, the great city. 13 Mizraim fathered the Ludim, the Anamim, the Lehabim, the Naphtuhim, 14 the Pathrusim, the Casluhim (from whom the Philistines came),[k] and the Caphtorim.

15 Canaan fathered Sidon his firstborn, and Heth,[l] 16 the Jebusite, the Amorite, the Girgashite, 17 the Hivite, the Arkite, the Sinite, 18 the Arvadite, the Zemarite, and the Hamathite. Afterward the clans of the Canaanites were scattered. 19 The territory of the Canaanites reached from Sidon toward Gerar as far as Gaza, and toward Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah, and Zeboiim as far as Lasha. 20 These are the sons of Ham, by their clans, by their languages, in their lands, in their nations.

21 To Shem also, the father of all the sons of Eber[m] and the older brother of Japheth,[n] children were born. 22 The sons of Shem: Elam, Asshur, Arpachshad, Lud, and Aram.[o] 23 The sons of Aram: Uz, Hul, Gether, and Mash.[p] 24 Arpachshad fathered Shelah,[q] and Shelah fathered Eber. 25 To Eber were born two sons. The name of the one was Peleg,[r] for in his days the earth was divided; and his brother's name was Joktan. 26 Joktan was the father of Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, and Jerah, 27 Hadoram, Uzal, and Diklah, 28 Obal, Abimael, and Sheba, 29 Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab. All these were Joktan's sons. 30 Their territory reached from Mesha toward Sephar, the hill country of the east. 31 These are the sons of Shem, by their clans, by their languages, in their lands, in their nations.

[32] Such were the clans descended from Noah's sons, line by line, nation by nation. From them the peoples branched out across the earth after the flood.[s]

Notes

- a (10:2) The names in this chapter are peoples and places as well as persons. Gomer is usually linked with the Cimmerians, Madai with the Medes, Javan with the Ionian Greeks, and Tubal and Meshech with peoples of Anatolia. The Septuagint adds Elisa to the sons of Japheth.
- b (10:4) The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint ("Rhodians"), and 1 Chronicles 1:7 read Rodanim, the people of Rhodes. In Hebrew script the letters d and r look very much alike.
- c (10:5) Literally "the coastlands of the nations," the shores and islands of the Mediterranean. Many scholars think the words "These are the sons of Japheth" have dropped out here (compare 10:20, 31).
- d (10:6) Mizraim is the Hebrew name for Egypt. Cush is the land south of Egypt; Put is probably Libya.
- e (10:8) Nimrod sounds like the Hebrew for "we will rebel" (marad). Jewish tradition made him the leader of the builders of Babel. "Mighty warrior" is gibbor, as in 6:4.
- f (10:9) "Before Yahweh" may mean "in Yahweh's sight," as a mark of greatness, or "in defiance of Yahweh."
- g (10:10) With different vowels the Hebrew for "and Calneh" can be read "all of them": "Babel, Erech, and Accad, all of them in the land of Shinar."
- h (10:10) Shinar is Babylonia, the land of Sumer and Akkad in southern Mesopotamia.
- i (10:11) Or "From that land Asshur went out." The Hebrew can be read either way; the Septuagint takes Asshur (Assur) as the subject.
- j (10:11) Literally "the broad places of the city," possibly a district of Nineveh rather than a separate city.
- k (10:14) Many scholars think this note belongs after "the Caphtorim," since Amos 9:7 and Jeremiah 47:4 say the Philistines came from Caphtor (probably Crete).
- l (10:15) Heth is the ancestor of the Hittites (see Genesis 23).
- m (10:21) The name Eber is linked with the word "Hebrew" (ivri).
- n (10:21) Or "the brother of Japheth the elder." The Hebrew does not make clear which brother was older; the Septuagint reads the second way.
- o (10:22) The Septuagint adds Cainan to the sons of Shem.
- p (10:23) 1 Chronicles 1:17 and the Septuagint read Meshech (Greek Mosoch).
- q (10:24) The Septuagint reads "Arpachshad fathered Cainan, and Cainan fathered Shelah," as in 11:12–13 and Luke 3:36.
- r (10:25) Peleg means "division," from palag, "divide." The division may be the scattering of peoples in 11:1–9, or the land divided by canals.

- s (10:32) The Masoretic Text names seventy peoples, a number of completeness (compare Deuteronomy 10:22). With its additions the Septuagint has more; Luke 10:1 has a similar variant, seventy or seventy-two sent out.

Chapter 11

1 All the earth had a single language, one set of words.[a] 2 As people
journeyed from the east,[b] they found a plain in the land of Shinar and
settled there. 3 They said to one another, "Come, let us make bricks
and bake them hard."[c] They had brick for stone and bitumen for mor-
tar. 4 They said, "Come, we will build a city for ourselves, and a tower
reaching up into the heavens, and win a name[d] for ourselves, or we
will be scattered across the face of the earth." 5 Yahweh came down to
see the city and the tower that the children of humankind had built.[e]
6 Yahweh said, "See, they are a single people with a single language,
and this is just the start of their doing. From now on nothing they
set out to do will be out of reach for them. 7 Come, we will go down
and mix up their speech[f] there, so that no one will understand what
another says." 8 So Yahweh scattered them from there over the face
of the whole earth, and they stopped building the city. 9 That is why
its name was Babel,[g] for there Yahweh confused the speech of the
entire earth, and from that place Yahweh dispersed them across the
whole earth.
10 These are the generations of Shem.[h] Two years after the flood, at
100 years of age, Shem fathered Arpachshad. 11 After Arpachshad's
birth Shem lived 500 more years, and other sons and daughters were
born to him.[i] 12 At 35 years of age Arpachshad fathered Shelah.[j] 13 After
Shelah's birth Arpachshad lived 403 more years, and other sons and
daughters were born to him. 14 At 30 years of age Shelah fathered
Eber. 15 After Eber's birth Shelah lived 403 more years, and other sons
and daughters were born to him. 16 At 34 years of age Eber fathered
Peleg. 17 After Peleg's birth Eber lived 430 more years, and other sons
and daughters were born to him. 18 At 30 years of age Peleg fathered
Reu. 19 After Reu's birth Peleg lived 209 more years, and other sons
and daughters were born to him. 20 At 32 years of age Reu fathered
Serug. 21 After Serug's birth Reu lived 207 more years, and other sons
and daughters were born to him. 22 At 30 years of age Serug fathered

Nahor. 23 After Nahor's birth Serug lived 200 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 24 At 29 years of age Nahor fathered Terah. 25 After Terah's birth Nahor lived 119 more years, and other sons and daughters were born to him. 26 At 70 years of age Terah fathered Abram,[k] Nahor, and Haran.

27 This is the account of Terah. Terah fathered Abram, Nahor, and Haran; and Haran fathered Lot. 28 Haran died during the lifetime of[l] Terah his father, in the land of his birth, in Ur of the Chaldeans.[m] 29 Abram and Nahor took wives for themselves. The name of Abram's wife was Sarai,[n] and the name of Nahor's wife was Milcah, the daughter of Haran, who was the father of Milcah and Iscah. 30 Now Sarai was barren; she had no child.[o] 31 Terah set out with Abram his son, with Lot the son of Haran, his grandson, and with Sarai, Abram's wife, his daughter-in-law. Together[p] they left Ur of the Chaldeans, heading for Canaan. But on reaching Haran[q] they stayed there. 32 Terah's life came to 205 years,[r] and he died in Haran.

Notes

- a (11:1) Literally "one lip and the same (or few) words."
- b (11:2) Or "journeyed eastward." Movement east runs through these chapters, away from Eden (3:24; 4:16).
- c (11:3) The Hebrew is full of sound play: nilbenah levenim, "let us brick bricks," and nisrefah lisrefah, "let us burn them for burning"; chemar (bitumen) and chomer (mortar). Southern Mesopotamia had little stone, so people built with baked brick.
- d (11:4) Hebrew shem, "name." The builders try to make a name for themselves; in 12:2 God promises to make a great name for Abram, a descendant of Shem (whose name means "name").
- e (11:5) The tower meant to reach the heavens is so small that Yahweh must "come down" to see it.
- f (11:7) Literally "their lip." "Let us confuse" is navlah, from balal. Its consonants (n-b-l) reverse those of "let us make bricks" (l-b-n) in 11:3: the builders' plan is turned back on them. On "let us," see 1:26.
- g (11:9) Babel (the Hebrew name for Babylon) sounds like balal, "confuse" or "mix." In Akkadian the city's name, Bab-ili, meant "gate of god"; Genesis answers with a pun: not the gate of God but the place of confusion. The Septuagint renders the name "Confusion."
- h (11:10) Another toledot heading. Ten generations from Shem to Abram mirror the ten from Adam to Noah in chapter 5.

- i (11:11) The Samaritan Pentateuch and the Septuagint add “and he died” after each person in this list, and the Samaritan also gives each total life span. Ages at fatherhood and years that follow differ. Masoretic: Arpachshad 35/403, Shelah 30/403, Eber 34/430, Peleg 30/209, Reu 32/207, Serug 30/200, Nahor 29/119. Samaritan: 135/303, 130/303, 134/270, 130/109, 132/107, 130/100, 79/69. Septuagint: 135/400 (Alexandrinus 430), then Cainan 130/330, Shelah 130/330, Eber 134/270 (Alexandrinus 370), Peleg 130/209, Reu 132/207, Serug 130/200, Nahor 179/125 (Alexandrinus 79/129). No Dead Sea Scroll preserves these numbers.
- j (11:12) The Septuagint has an extra generation here: Arpachshad fathers Cainan, and Cainan (130 years, then 330 more) fathers Shelah. Luke 3:36 includes this Cainan, and Jubilees 8 also knows him as Kainam. He is absent from the Masoretic Text, the Samaritan Pentateuch, and 1 Chronicles 1:18, 24.
- k (11:26) Abram means “exalted father”; in 17:5 he is renamed Abraham. He is named first but may not be the eldest: if Terah died at 205 (11:32) and Abram left Haran at 75 after his father’s death (12:4; Acts 7:4), Abram was born when Terah was 130.
- l (11:28) Literally “on the face of,” that is, while his father was still alive.
- m (11:28) Ur was a great city of southern Mesopotamia. “Of the Chaldeans” uses a later name for the region, updating it for readers. The Septuagint reads “in the land of the Chaldeans.”
- n (11:29) Sarai probably means “princess”; in 17:15 she is renamed Sarah. Jewish tradition identifies Iscah with Sarai, but the text does not say so.
- o (11:30) The Hebrew says it twice (“barren; there was to her no child”), using a rare word for child (valad). The whole story of the promise to Abram begins from this emptiness.
- p (11:31) Literally “they went out with them.” The Septuagint and Vulgate read “he brought them out.”
- q (11:31) The city Haran (Hebrew Charan) in northern Mesopotamia is spelled differently in Hebrew from the name of Terah’s son Haran.
- r (11:32) The Samaritan Pentateuch reads 145 years. By that number Terah died in the year Abram left Haran (11:26; 12:4), which matches Stephen’s words in Acts 7:4.

Chapter 12

1 Yahweh said to Abram, “Go out[a] from your land, from your relatives,
and from your father’s house, to the land that I will show you. 2 I
will make of you a great nation; I will bless you and make your name
renowned, and you will be a blessing.[b] 3 I will bless those who bless
you, and whoever treats you with contempt I will curse. And in you
all the families[c] of the earth will be blessed.”[d]

4 So Abram went, as Yahweh had told him, and Lot went with him.
Abram was seventy-five years old when he left Haran. 5 Abram took
his wife Sarai and his nephew Lot, with all the wealth they had
amassed and the persons[e] they had gained in Haran, and they left for
Canaan. So they arrived in Canaan.[f] 6 Abram passed through the land
as far as the place of Shechem, to the oak of Moreh.[g] At that time the
Canaanites were in the land. 7 Then Yahweh appeared to Abram and
said, "To your offspring[h] I will give this land." So he built an altar there
to Yahweh, who had appeared to him. 8 From there he went on to the
hills east of Bethel and set up his tent between Bethel on the west
and Ai on the east. He built an altar there to Yahweh and called on
Yahweh's name. 9 Then Abram journeyed on, going by stages toward
the Negev.[i]

10 A famine struck the land, and Abram went down into Egypt to stay
as a foreigner,[j] for the famine weighed heavily on the land. 11 As he
was about to enter Egypt, he said to Sarai his wife, "Look, I know that
you are a beautiful woman to see. 12 When the Egyptians see you, they
will say, 'This is his wife.' Then they will kill me, but they will let you
live. 13 Tell them you are my sister,[k] I beg you, so that I am treated well
for your sake and kept alive thanks to you."

14 When Abram came into Egypt, the Egyptians saw that the woman
was very beautiful. 15 Pharaoh's officials[l] saw her and praised her
to Pharaoh, and the woman was taken into Pharaoh's house. 16
He treated Abram well because of her, and Abram acquired sheep,
cattle, male donkeys, male and female servants, female donkeys, and
camels.[m] 17 But Yahweh afflicted Pharaoh and his household with
severe plagues on account of Abram's wife Sarai.[n] 18 So Pharaoh
summoned Abram and said, "What is this you have done to me? Why
did you not tell me that she was your wife? 19 Why did you claim,
'She is my sister,' and let me take her as a wife? Here she is, your
wife. Take her and be gone!" 20 Then Pharaoh gave his men orders
concerning him, and they sent him away with his wife and all that
he had.[o]

Notes

- a (12:1) Literally “Go, for yourself” (Hebrew lekh-lekha), a phrase that stresses personal departure. It returns in 22:2, framing Abraham’s story with two calls to go.
- b (12:2) Literally “be a blessing.” Some scholars repoint the Hebrew to read “and it (your name) will be a blessing.”
- c (12:3) Or “clans.” The Septuagint reads “tribes.”
- d (12:3) Or “will bless themselves by you,” that is, use your name in their blessings. The Hebrew verb form allows both senses. The New Testament reads it as a promise that the nations will share Abraham’s blessing (Acts 3:25; Galatians 3:8).
- e (12:5) Literally “the souls” (nephesh), probably servants and members of the household. Later Jewish tradition read it as the people Abram and Sarai had won to faith in the one God.
- f (12:5) Brenton’s Septuagint lacks “And they came to the land of Canaan,” though he notes that Codex Alexandrinus has it, as the Hebrew does.
- g (12:6) Or “the terebinth of Moreh,” a large tree. Moreh may mean “teacher,” suggesting a place where oracles were sought. The Septuagint reads “the high oak.”
- h (12:7) Literally “seed,” here and throughout. The Hebrew word is singular in form but usually collective. Paul builds on the singular form in Galatians 3:16.
- i (12:9) The Negev is the dry southern region of Canaan. The word also means “south.” The Septuagint reads “the wilderness.”
- j (12:10) Hebrew gur, “to live as a resident foreigner,” without the rights of a native. The same verb shapes much of the patriarchs’ story.
- k (12:13) Sarai was in fact Abram’s half sister (20:12). The half-truth was still a deception, and the story does not approve it.
- l (12:15) Or “princes.” “Pharaoh” is an Egyptian title meaning “great house,” not a personal name.
- m (12:16) The mention of camels here and elsewhere in Genesis is debated, since large-scale camel domestication is dated later than the usual dates for Abraham. Some see it as the narrator updating the details for later readers.
- n (12:17) Literally “because of the word (or matter) of Sarai.”
- o (12:20) Brenton notes that Codex Alexandrinus adds “and Lot with him,” which prepares for 13:1.

Chapter 13

1 So Abram went up from Egypt into the Negev, he and his wife and
all that he had, and Lot with him. 2 Abram was very rich[a] in livestock,
in silver, and in gold. 3 He went on by stages from the Negev as far as
Bethel, to the place where his tent had been at the beginning, between
Bethel and Ai, 4 It was the site of the altar he had first built there. And
there Abram invoked the name of Yahweh.

5 Lot, who traveled with Abram, also owned sheep, cattle, and tents.
6 But the land could not support them both living together, because
their possessions were so great that they could not stay together.
7 Strife arose between Abram's herdsmen and Lot's herdsmen. The
Canaanites and the Perizzites were then dwelling in the land. 8 Then
Abram said to Lot, "Please, let there be no quarrel between me and
you, or between my herders and your herders, for we are family.[b] 9
Is not the whole land in front of you? Please separate from me. If
you go to the left, I will go to the right; if you go to the right, I will
go to the left." 10 Lot raised his eyes and saw how the whole Jordan
plain[c] was watered throughout, like Yahweh's garden, like Egypt, all
the way toward Zoar.[d] That was before Yahweh destroyed Sodom and
Gomorrah. 11 So Lot selected the entire Jordan plain for himself and
journeyed eastward.[e] In this way the two men parted. 12 Abram dwelt
in Canaan, but Lot dwelt among the towns of the plain, pitching his
tent near Sodom. 13 Now the people of Sodom were evil, great sinners
against Yahweh.[f]
14 After Lot had separated from him, Yahweh said to Abram, "Lift up
your eyes and look from the place where you are, northward and
southward, eastward and westward,[g] 15 Every bit of land within your
sight I will give to you and your descendants for all time. 16 I will make
your descendants like the dust on the ground in number. If anyone
could count the dust, then your descendants could be counted too. 17
Get up, walk through the land, its length and its breadth, for I will
give it to you." 18 Abram moved his tent and went to live by the oaks
of Mamre[h] at Hebron, and he built an altar there to Yahweh.

Notes

- a (13:2) Literally "very heavy." The same root gives the Hebrew word for "glory."
- b (13:8) Literally "for we are men, brothers." "Brother" is often used for any close relative; Lot was Abram's nephew.
- c (13:10) Hebrew kikkar, literally "circle" or "round," the well-watered region around the southern Jordan.
- d (13:10) The Septuagint reads "Zogora." Some scholars suggest the original may have read "Zoan," a city in Egypt, which would fit the comparison with Egypt. This is uncertain.

- e (13:11) Or “from the east.” The Septuagint reads “from the east.” The Hebrew miqqedem can mean either.
- f (13:13) Literally “evil and sinners to Yahweh, very.” The Septuagint reads “before God.”
- g (13:14) Literally “seaward,” toward the Mediterranean.
- h (13:18) Or “terebinths of Mamre.” The Hebrew is plural; the Septuagint reads the singular “oak.”

Chapter 14

1 In the days of Amraphel king of Shinar, Arioch king of Ellasar,
Chedorlaomer king of Elam, and Tidal king of Goiim,[a] 2 these kings
made war against Bera king of Sodom, Birsha king of Gomorrah,
Shinab king of Admah, Shemeber king of Zeboiim, and the king of
Bela, that is, Zoar. 3 These all joined together in the Valley of Siddim
(the Salt Sea).[b] 4 Twelve years they had been subject to Chedorlaomer;
in the thirteenth they revolted. 5 In the fourteenth year Chedorlaomer
and the kings who were with him came and defeated the Rephaim[c]
in Ashteroth-karnaim, the Zuzim in Ham, the Emim in Shaveh-
kiriathaim, 6 and the Horites in their hills of Seir, reaching to El-paran
at the edge of the wilderness. 7 Then they turned back and came
to En-mishpat,[d] that is, Kadesh, and defeated all the territory of the
Amalekites, and also the Amorites who lived in Hazazon-tamar. 8
Then the king of Sodom, the king of Gomorrah, the king of Admah,
the king of Zeboiim, and the king of Bela, that is, Zoar, went out
and drew up their battle lines against them in the Valley of Siddim, 9
against Chedorlaomer king of Elam, Tidal king of Goiim, Amraphel
king of Shinar, and Arioch king of Ellasar, four kings against five. 10
The Valley of Siddim was riddled with bitumen pits.[e] When the kings
of Sodom and Gomorrah fled, some of their men fell in there, and the
rest escaped to the hills. 11 The enemy took all the goods of Sodom
and Gomorrah and all their food, and went away. 12 They also took
Lot, the son of Abram’s brother, and his goods, and went away, for
he was living in Sodom.
13 A fugitive came and reported it to Abram the Hebrew.[f] Abram was
camped by the large trees owned by Mamre the Amorite, brother of
Eshcol and Aner, and these men were Abram’s allies.[g] 14 When Abram

heard that his relative had been taken captive, he called out[h] his trained men, born in his household, 318 of them, and pursued as far as Dan.[i] 15 During the night he split up his men and attacked them, he and his servants. He defeated them and chased them all the way to Hobah, which lies north[j] of Damascus. 16 He brought back all the goods, and he also brought back his relative Lot and his goods, along with the women and the people.

17 After Abram returned from defeating Chedorlaomer and the kings who were with him, the king of Sodom went out to meet him at the Valley of Shaveh, that is, the King's Valley. 18 And Melchizedek[k] king of Salem[l] brought out bread and wine. He was priest of El Elyon.[m] 19 He blessed Abram and said, "Blessed be Abram by El Elyon, Maker[n] of heaven and earth. 20 And blessed be El Elyon, who has delivered your enemies into your hand." Then Abram handed him a tenth part of everything.[o]

21 The king of Sodom then said to Abram, "Give the people to me, and keep the possessions for yourself." 22 But Abram said to the king of Sodom, "I have raised my hand[p] to Yahweh,[q] El Elyon, Maker of heaven and earth, 23 I swear that I will accept nothing of yours, not even a thread or a shoelace, so that you can never claim, 'I enriched Abram.' 24 I want nothing except what the young men have already consumed, and the share for the men who marched with me: Aner, Eshcol, and Mamre. Let them take their share."

Notes

- a (14:1) Or "king of nations," as the Septuagint reads. None of these four kings has been securely identified in other ancient records, though the names fit known name types from Mesopotamia, Elam, and Anatolia.
- b (14:3) The Salt Sea is the Dead Sea. The note "that is…" updates the place name for later readers, as several notes in this chapter do.
- c (14:5) The Rephaim, Zuzim, and Emim were peoples remembered as unusually tall (compare Deuteronomy 2:10–11, 20). The Septuagint reads "the giants" for Rephaim.
- d (14:7) En-mishpat means "spring of judgment." The Septuagint translates it "the well of judgment."
- e (14:10) Literally "pits, pits of bitumen," a Hebrew way of saying "full of pits." The Dead Sea region is known for natural asphalt.

- f (14:13) The first use of “Hebrew” in the Bible. The Septuagint translates it “the one who crossed over” (Brenton: “the passer”), linking it with the root avar, “to cross,” though the word is more likely connected with Eber (10:21; 11:14).
- g (14:13) Literally “lords of a covenant with Abram.”
- h (14:14) Literally “emptied out” or “drew out,” an unusual use of the verb. The Septuagint reads “numbered,” and a different Hebrew verb lies behind some other ancient witnesses. The meaning “mustered” is likely.
- i (14:14) Dan was named later (Judges 18:29); the narrator uses the name his readers knew.
- j (14:15) Literally “on the left of,” that is, to the north for someone facing east.
- k (14:18) Melchizedek means “my king is righteousness” or “king of righteousness.” He is taken up in Psalm 110:4 and Hebrews 5–7, and in the Qumran text known as 11QMelchizedek.
- l (14:18) Salem probably means Jerusalem (compare Psalm 76:2). The name sounds like shalom, “peace” (Hebrews 7:2).
- m (14:18) Hebrew El Elyon, “God Most High.” Elyon means “highest.” Here Abram identifies this God with Yahweh (14:22).
- n (14:19) Or “Creator” or “Owner.” The Hebrew qoneh can mean either “maker” or “possessor.”
- o (14:20) Literally “he gave him a tenth from all.” The Hebrew does not name the subject; Hebrews 7:4 understands that Abram gave the tenth to Melchizedek.
- p (14:22) A gesture of taking an oath. The Septuagint reads “I will stretch out my hand.”
- q (14:22) The Masoretic Text has the name Yahweh here, and Brenton’s Septuagint also has “the Lord” (kyrios): “the Lord the most high God.” Some other ancient witnesses are reported to lack the divine name and read only “God Most High” (El Elyon), as in 14:18–20.

Chapter 15

1 After these things the word of Yahweh came to Abram in a vision:
“Do not be afraid, Abram. I am your shield;[a] your reward will be very
great.” 2 But Abram said, “Lord Yahweh,[b] what will you give me, since
I go on childless, and the heir of my house[c] is Eliezer of Damascus?” 3
And Abram said, “Look, you have given me no offspring, so a member
of my household will be my heir.” 4 Then the word of Yahweh came to
him: “This man will not be your heir; one who comes from your own
body will be your heir.” 5 He brought him outside and said, “Look up
at the sky and count the stars, if you are able to count them.” Then he
said to him, “So shall your offspring be.” 6 Abram believed[d] Yahweh,
and he counted it to him as righteousness.[e]

7 He said to him, "I am Yahweh who brought you out of Ur of the
Chaldeans, to give you this land to possess." 8 But he said, "Lord
Yahweh, how will I know that I will possess it?" 9 He told him,
"Fetch me a heifer, a she-goat, and a ram, each three years old, along
with a turtledove and a young pigeon." 10 Abram fetched all these,
split them down the middle, and set each half facing its partner; the
birds, though, he left whole. 11 When birds of prey came down on the
carcasses, Abram drove them away.[f]
12 As the sun was going down, a deep sleep[g] fell on Abram, and a
dread, a great darkness, fell upon him. 13 Then Yahweh said to Abram,
"Know for certain that your offspring will be foreigners in a land
that is not theirs. They will be enslaved and oppressed there for four
hundred years.[h] 14 But I will bring judgment on the nation they serve,
and afterward they will come out with great possessions. 15 But you
yourself will join your ancestors in peace, and you will be laid in the
grave after a long and full life. 16 In the fourth generation[i] they will
come back here, for the guilt of the Amorites is not yet complete."
17 After the sun went down and darkness fell, a smoking cooking
pot and a blazing torch moved between the halves of the animals.[j]
18 On that day Yahweh established a covenant[k] with Abram: "I am
giving this land to your descendants, from the stream of Egypt[l] to the
great river, the Euphrates: 19 the land of the Kenites, the Kenizzites,
the Kadmonites, 20 the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Rephaim, 21 the
Amorites, the Canaanites, the Girgashites, and the Jebusites."[m]

Notes

- a (15:1) Hebrew magen, "shield." A slight change of vowels gives "I give you a gift (or payment)," which some scholars prefer because of "reward." The Septuagint reads "I shield you."
- b (15:2) Hebrew Adonai YHWH, "my Lord Yahweh." The Masoretic Text points the name here with the vowels of Elohim, so that it is read "God," and older English Bibles print "Lord GOD." Brenton's Septuagint reads "Master and Lord."
- c (15:2) The Hebrew is obscure: literally "the son of mesheq of my house is Damascus Eliezer." Mesheq may be a wordplay on Dammesheq, "Damascus," or a word meaning "acquisition." The Septuagint takes Masek as the name of Eliezer's mother.

- d (15:6) Or “trusted.” The Hebrew he’emin comes from the root of amen, “firm” or “reliable.” The verse is quoted in Romans 4:3, Galatians 3:6, and James 2:23; the Septuagint reads “Abram believed God.”
- e (15:6) The Hebrew does not name the subject of “counted.” The usual reading is that Yahweh counted Abram’s faith as righteousness. A minority reading is that Abram counted Yahweh’s promise as an act of righteousness.
- f (15:11) Brenton’s Septuagint reads “Abram sat down by them.” Brenton suggests the translators read a Hebrew verb meaning “sat” in place of the one meaning “drove back.”
- g (15:12) Hebrew tardemah, the same deep sleep that fell on the human in 2:21. The Septuagint reads “trance” (ekstasis).
- h (15:13) Exodus 12:40 gives 430 years. The Septuagint at Exodus 12:40, and reportedly the Samaritan Pentateuch, count that span to include the time in Canaan as well as in Egypt, and Paul counts 430 years from the promise to the Law (Galatians 3:17).
- i (15:16) Hebrew dor, “generation,” may here mean a long lifetime or era of about a century, matching the 400 years of 15:13.
- j (15:17) In ancient covenant rites the parties walked between cut animals, calling a like fate on themselves if they broke the agreement (compare Jeremiah 34:18–20). Here only the fire, a sign of God’s presence, passes through.
- k (15:18) Literally “cut a covenant,” the usual Hebrew idiom, which matches the cut animals.
- l (15:18) Probably the Wadi el-Arish, the seasonal stream on the border between Canaan and Egypt, rather than the Nile.
- m (15:21) The Septuagint (Brenton: “the Evites”) and some other ancient witnesses add “the Hivites” to the list. This translation follows the Hebrew, which has ten peoples.

Chapter 16

1 Now Sarai, Abram’s wife, had borne him no children. She had an
Egyptian slave woman[a] whose name was Hagar. 2 So Sarai said to
Abram, “Look, Yahweh has kept me from bearing children. Please go
in to my slave woman; perhaps I can build a family through her.”[b] And
Abram listened to what Sarai said. 3 After Abram had spent ten years
living in Canaan, Abram’s wife Sarai brought her servant, Hagar the
Egyptian, and gave her to Abram as a wife.[c] 4 He went in to Hagar, and
she conceived. When she saw that she had conceived, her mistress
became slight[d] in her eyes. 5 Then Sarai said to Abram, “The wrong
done to me is on you![e] I put my slave woman in your arms, and when
she saw that she had conceived, I became slight in her eyes. May

Yahweh judge between me and you." 6 But Abram said to Sarai, "Look, your slave woman is in your hands. Do to her whatever seems good to you." Then Sarai treated her harshly,[f] and she ran away from her.
7 The angel of Yahweh[g] came upon her at a spring in the wilderness, the spring beside the Shur road. 8 He asked, "Hagar, Sarai's slave girl, where have you come from, and where are you headed?" "I am fleeing from Sarai my mistress," she answered. 9 Then the angel of Yahweh told her, "Return to your mistress and humble yourself under her hand." 10 The angel of Yahweh also said to her, "I will greatly multiply your offspring, so that they cannot be counted for multitude." 11 And the angel of Yahweh said to her, "Look, you are pregnant and will give birth to a son. You shall call his name Ishmael,[h] for Yahweh has heard your affliction. 12 He will be a wild donkey[i] of a man, his hand raised against all and the hands of all raised against him, and he will live at odds with[j] all his kin." 13 She gave a name to Yahweh, who had addressed her: "You are El Roi,"[k] for she said, "Have I truly looked, even here, upon the one who sees me?"[l] 14 So the well came to be called Beer-lahai-roi;[m] it is between Kadesh and Bered.
15 Hagar bore Abram a son, and Abram called the name of his son, whom Hagar bore, Ishmael. 16 Abram was eighty-six years old when Hagar bore Ishmael to Abram.

Notes

- a (16:1) Hebrew shiphchah, a female slave or servant who belonged to her mistress. Ancient marriage contracts from Mesopotamia describe a childless wife giving such a woman to her husband to bear children for her.
- b (16:2) Literally "I will be built from her." There is a wordplay between banah, "to build," and ben, "son."
- c (16:3) Or "as a concubine." Hebrew ishshah, "wife" or "woman." Hagar became a secondary wife; she remained Sarai's servant (16:6).
- d (16:4) Literally "light," the opposite of "heavy" or "honored." She looked down on her mistress.
- e (16:5) Literally "My violence (chamas) is upon you," meaning "you are responsible for the wrong I suffer."
- f (16:6) Hebrew anah, "to afflict" or "humble," the same verb used of Israel's oppression in Egypt (15:13; Exodus 1:11–12).
- g (16:7) The first appearance of "the angel (or messenger) of Yahweh." In several passages this figure speaks as God himself (16:10, 13; 22:11–12, 15–16).

- h (16:11) Ishmael means “God hears.”
- i (16:12) Hebrew pere, the wild donkey or onager of the desert, an image of a free, untamed life rather than an insult. The Septuagint reads “a wild man.”
- j (16:12) Or “he will live to the east of” or “alongside.” The Hebrew al-pene, literally “upon the face of,” has all three senses. The Septuagint reads “in the presence of.”
- k (16:13) Hebrew El Roi, “God who sees me” or “God of seeing.”
- l (16:13) The Hebrew is difficult; literally “Have I even here seen after the one who sees me?” Possible senses include “Have I seen God and lived after seeing him?” (by a small emendation) and “Have I seen the back of the one who sees me?” (compare Exodus 33:23).
- m (16:14) Beer-lahai-roi probably means “well of the living one who sees me.” The Septuagint reads “the well of him whom I have openly seen.”

Chapter 17

1 When Abram was ninety-nine years old, Yahweh appeared to Abram
and said to him, “I am El Shaddai.[a] Walk before me and be blameless,[b]
2 and I will set my covenant between me and you and multiply you
very greatly.” 3 Then Abram fell on his face, and God spoke with
him, saying, 4 “As for me, here is my covenant with you: you will be
the father of a multitude of nations. 5 No longer shall your name be
called Abram; your name shall be Abraham,[c] for I have made you the
father of a multitude of nations. 6 I will make you abundantly fruitful;
nations will come out of you, and kings will be among your descen-
dants. 7 I will establish my covenant between me and you and your
offspring after you throughout their generations, as an everlasting
covenant, to be God to you and to your offspring after you. 8 And I will
give to you and to your offspring after you the land where you are
living as a foreigner, all the land of Canaan, as a possession forever.
And I will be their God.”
9 God said to Abraham, “As for you, you shall keep my covenant, you
and your offspring after you throughout their generations. 10 This is
my covenant, which you shall keep, between me and you and your
offspring after you: every male among you shall be circumcised. 11 You
shall circumcise the flesh of your foreskins, and it will be the sign
of the covenant between me and you. 12 Generation after generation,
each male among you is to be circumcised on his eighth day, both the
slave born in your household and the one purchased with silver from

a foreigner not of your line. 13 Whether he is born in your household
or purchased with your silver, he must be circumcised. In this way
my covenant will be marked on your bodies as a covenant that lasts
forever. 14 An uncircumcised male, one who has not had the flesh of
his foreskin[d] circumcised, will be cut off[e] from his kin, because he has
violated my covenant."
15 God said to Abraham, "As for Sarai your wife, you shall not call
her name Sarai, for Sarah[f] shall be her name. 16 I will bless her, and I
will also give you a son by her. I will bless her, and she will become
nations;[g] kings of peoples will come from her." 17 Then Abraham fell
on his face and laughed,[h] and said in his heart, "Can a child be born to
a man a hundred years old? Can Sarah, who is ninety years old, give
birth?" 18 Abraham said to God, "Oh, that Ishmael might live in your
favor!" 19 God said, "No, but[i] Sarah your wife will bear you a son, and
you shall call his name Isaac.[j] I will establish my covenant with him as
an everlasting covenant for his offspring after him. 20 As for Ishmael,
I have heard you.[k] Look, I will bless him and make him fruitful and
multiply him very greatly. He will father twelve chieftains, and I will
make him a great nation. 21 But my covenant I will establish with Isaac,
whom Sarah will bear to you at this set time next year." 22 When he
had finished speaking with him, God went up from Abraham.
23 That same day Abraham took his son Ishmael and every male of his
household, whether born in his house or purchased with his silver,
and circumcised the flesh of their foreskins, just as God had told him.
24 Abraham was ninety-nine years old when he was circumcised in
the flesh of his foreskin. 25 And Ishmael his son was thirteen years
old when he was circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin. 26 On that
very day Abraham was circumcised, and Ishmael his son. 27 And all
the men of his house, those born in the house and those bought with
money from a foreigner, were circumcised with him.

Notes

- a (17:1) Hebrew El Shaddai, traditionally "God Almighty." The meaning of Shaddai is uncertain. Proposals include "of the mountain," "of the fields," and "the one who is sufficient." "Almighty" follows the ancient Greek and Latin tradition in other books. In this verse Brenton's Septuagint reads "I am your God."

- b (17:1) Hebrew tamim, “whole,” “complete,” or “with integrity.” It is used of Noah in 6:9.
- c (17:5) Abram means “exalted father.” Abraham sounds like av hamon, “father of a multitude.” The name may be a longer form of Abram, given new meaning by the promise.
- d (17:14) The Septuagint adds “on the eighth day,” and some other ancient witnesses are reported to have the same addition.
- e (17:14) “Cut off” (karat) may mean death, exclusion from the community, or the ending of one’s family line. The same verb is used for “cutting” a covenant (15:18).
- f (17:15) Sarai and Sarah are two forms of one name meaning “princess.” The change marks her new role as mother of nations and kings.
- g (17:16) Brenton’s Septuagint reads “I will bless him, and he will become nations,” referring to the son.
- h (17:17) Hebrew tsachaq, “laugh,” the root of the name Isaac. Laughter returns in 18:12–15 and 21:6, 9.
- i (17:19) Or “Truly” or “Yes, indeed.” The Hebrew aval can confirm or correct. The Septuagint reads “Yes.”
- j (17:19) Isaac (Hebrew Yitschaq) means “he laughs.”
- k (17:20) Hebrew shema’tikha, a play on the name Ishmael, “God hears.”

Chapter 18

1 Yahweh appeared to Abraham[a] by the large trees of Mamre as he
was sitting at the opening of his tent in the warmest part of the day.
2 Raising his eyes, he saw three men standing close by. On seeing
them he hurried from his tent door to greet them and bowed low
to the earth. 3 He said, “Sir,[b] if I have gained your approval, please
do not go on past your servant. 4 Let some water be fetched so you
can wash your feet, and then rest yourselves beneath the tree. 5 I will
bring a morsel of bread for you to refresh your hearts.[c] Then you
can continue, now that you have come by your servant’s way.” “Go
ahead,” they answered, “just as you say.” 6 Abraham hastened into the
tent to Sarah. “Hurry,” he said, “about twenty quarts[d] of fine flour!
Knead it and bake some loaves.” 7 Then Abraham ran to the herd, took
a calf, tender and good, and gave it to a young man, who hurried to
prepare it. 8 Then he took curds[e] and milk and the calf he had prepared
and set it before them. He stood by them under the tree while they ate.
9 They said to him, “Where is Sarah your wife?” He said, “There, in the
tent.” 10 One of them said, “I will come back to you when this season

comes round again,[f] and then Sarah your wife will hold a son." Sarah
was listening at the door of the tent behind him. 11 Now Abraham
and Sarah were old, well along in years. The way of women[g] had
ceased for Sarah. 12 So Sarah laughed to herself, saying, "After I am
worn out, shall I have pleasure,[h] with my lord so old?" 13 Yahweh
asked Abraham, "What made Sarah laugh and say, 'Will I truly give
birth, old as I am?' 14 Is any matter too wondrous[i] for Yahweh? At
the appointed time, when this season comes round again, I will come
back to you, and Sarah will have a son." 15 But Sarah denied it, saying,
"I did not laugh," for she was afraid. He said, "No, you did laugh."
16 Then the men got up from there and looked down toward Sodom,
and Abraham went with them to send them on their way. 17 Yahweh
said, "Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do, 18 since
Abraham will surely become a great and mighty nation, and all the
nations of the earth will be blessed in him? 19 I have chosen[j] him so that
he will direct his sons and his household after him to follow the path
of Yahweh, practicing justice and righteousness, and then Yahweh
can fulfill for Abraham everything he promised him." 20 Then Yahweh
said, "The cry[k] over Sodom and Gomorrah is enormous, and their
wrongdoing is extremely grave. 21 Let me go down and see if their
deeds fully match the outcry that has reached me. If not, I will know."
22 The men turned away and headed toward Sodom, but Abraham still
stood in Yahweh's presence.[l] 23 Abraham drew near and said, "Will
you indeed destroy the righteous along with the wicked? 24 What if
the city holds fifty who are righteous? Would you destroy it then,
and not forgive[m] the place for the sake of those fifty? 25 Surely you
would never do such a thing, killing the righteous together with the
wicked, treating the one the same as the other! Surely not you! Will
the Judge of the whole earth not act justly?" 26 Yahweh answered, "If
in Sodom I find fifty righteous within the city, I will forgive the entire
place for them." 27 Abraham answered and said, "Look, I have dared to
speak to the Lord, though I am but dust and ashes.[n] 28 What if the fifty
righteous are five short? For want of five, will you destroy the whole
city?" He answered, "If I find forty-five there, I will not destroy it."
29 Abraham spoke to him again: "Perhaps only forty will be found in

it?" He replied, "Because of those forty I will not do it." 30 Then he said, "Please do not let the Lord be angry, and I will speak. Suppose thirty are found there." He said, "I will not do it if I find thirty there." 31 He said, "Please note that I have presumed to speak to the Lord: what if twenty are found there?" He answered, "I will not destroy it, for the sake of the twenty." 32 He said, "May the Lord not be angry if I speak only this once more: what if ten are found there?" He answered, "I will not destroy it, for the sake of the ten." 33 When Yahweh had finished speaking to Abraham, he went his way, and Abraham returned to his place.

Notes

- a (18:1) The Septuagint reads "God appeared to him." The chapter moves between Yahweh and the three men without explaining how they relate. Christian readers have long seen a hint of the Trinity here; Jewish tradition usually sees Yahweh accompanied by angels (19:1).
- b (18:3) The Hebrew consonants can be read as adoni, "my lord," a polite address to a guest, or Adonai, "Lord," as the Masoretic vowels have it. Abraham may not yet know who the visitor is.
- c (18:5) Literally "sustain your hearts." The modest offer of "a bite of bread" becomes a lavish meal, an example of ancient hospitality (compare Hebrews 13:2).
- d (18:6) Hebrew "three seahs." The seah was a dry measure of uncertain size, often reckoned at about 7 quarts (7.3 liters), so three seahs is about 20 quarts or 5 gallons (22 liters) of flour; estimates vary widely, and some are much smaller. Either way it is a lavish amount for three guests.
- e (18:8) Or "butter." Hebrew chem'ah usually means curdled milk or yogurt.
- f (18:10) Literally "at the time of life," probably meaning "when the time comes round again," about a year from now. The Septuagint reads "according to this time, seasonably."
- g (18:11) A polite expression for menstruation.
- h (18:12) Hebrew ednah, related to Eden, "delight." Brenton notes that the Septuagint reads "The thing has not yet happened to me until now," taking the word in a different sense.
- i (18:14) Or "too hard." Hebrew pala, used of things beyond human power. Compare Jeremiah 32:17, 27 and Luke 1:37.
- j (18:19) Literally "I have known him," in the sense of a chosen, personal relationship.
- k (18:20) Hebrew ze'aqah, the cry of victims for help against injustice. Ezekiel 16:49 names Sodom's sins as pride, excess, and failure to help the poor and needy.
- l (18:22) Ancient Jewish tradition lists this verse among the "corrections of the scribes" (tiqqune sopherim). It says the original read "Yahweh remained standing

before Abraham," changed out of reverence. No surviving manuscript has that reading.

- m (18:24) Literally "lift up," that is, forgive or bear with the place.
- n (18:27) Hebrew aphar wa'epher, a sound pair. Compare 3:19.

Chapter 19

1 At evening the two angels reached Sodom. Lot was seated at
Sodom's gate,[a] and when he saw them he rose to greet them and
bowed low, face to the earth. 2 "Please, my lords," he said, "turn in to
the house of your servant, spend the night, and wash your feet. Then
you may rise early and go your ways." "No," they replied, "we will
spend the night in the square." 3 He urged them so insistently that
they came aside with him into his house. He prepared a meal for them
and baked flatbread, and they ate. 4 Before they lay down, the men of
the city, the men of Sodom, surrounded the house, young and old, all
the people from every quarter. 5 They shouted to Lot, "Where are the
men who came to your house tonight? Send them out to us so we can
know them!"[b] 6 Lot stepped outside to them in the doorway, closing
the door after him. 7 He said, "Please, my brothers, do not do this evil.
8 See, I have two daughters who have never known a man. I will bring
them out to you; do with them as you please. But leave these men
alone, since they have come under the shade of my roof."[c] 9 "Out of
the way!" they answered. And they said, "This fellow came here as
an outsider, and now he sets himself up as judge![d] We will deal worse
with you than with them." They shoved hard against Lot himself and
moved in to smash the door. 10 But the two men inside put out their
hands, pulled Lot back into the house to them, and closed the door.
11 They struck the men who were at the entrance of the house, small
and great, with a blinding light,[e] so that they wore themselves out
trying to find the entrance.
12 Then the men said to Lot, "Who else do you have here? A son-in-
law, your sons, your daughters, anyone you have in the city, bring
them out of this place, 13 for we are about to destroy this place, because
the outcry against its people has grown great before Yahweh, and
Yahweh has sent us to destroy it." 14 Lot went out and spoke to his
sons-in-law, the men pledged to marry[f] his daughters. "Up! Leave this

place," he said, "for Yahweh is going to destroy the city." But to his sons-in-law he seemed to be jesting.
15 At daybreak the angels pressed Lot to hurry. "Up! Take your wife and the two daughters you have here, or you will be swept off in the city's punishment."[g] 16 Still he delayed. Since Yahweh had pity on him, the men took hold of his hand and the hands of his wife and two daughters, led him out, and left him beyond the city. 17 When they had brought them outside, one[h] said, "Flee for your life! Do not look back, and do not stand still anywhere in the whole plain. Escape to the hills, or you will be swept away." 18 But Lot said to them, "Oh no, my lord![i] 19 Your servant has won your favor, and you have been very kind to me in keeping me alive. But I cannot flee as far as the hills; the disaster would catch me and I would die. 20 Look, this town is near enough to flee to, and it is a small one. Please let me escape there. Is it not small? Then my life will be spared." 21 He said to him, "Very well, I grant you this request too.[j] I will not overthrow the town you have spoken of. 22 Hurry! Escape to that town, for I can do nothing until you have come to it." For this reason the town was named Zoar.[k]
23 The sun had come up over the earth by the time Lot reached Zoar. 24 Then Yahweh rained down on Sodom and Gomorrah sulfur and fire from Yahweh out of the heavens.[l] 25 He overthrew those cities and the whole plain, all the inhabitants of the cities, and what grew on the ground. 26 But Lot's wife looked back[m] from behind him, and she was turned to a pillar of salt.
27 Abraham got up early in the morning and went to the place where he had stood before Yahweh. 28 He looked out over Sodom and Gomorrah and all the land of the plain, and there he saw smoke rising from the land, like the smoke of a kiln. 29 So when God destroyed the cities of the plain, God remembered Abraham and sent Lot out of the midst of the overthrow, when he overthrew the cities where Lot had lived.
30 Lot left Zoar and went up to dwell in the hills, he and his two daughters, since he was afraid to stay in Zoar. He and his two daughters made their home in a cave. 31 The firstborn said to the younger, "Our father is old, and there is no man in the land[n] to come in to

us in the way of all the earth. 32 Come, let us make our father drink wine, and we will lie with him, so that we may preserve offspring from our father." 33 So they made their father drink wine that night. The firstborn went in and lay with her father; he did not know when she lay down or when she got up.[o] 34 Next day the elder said to the younger, "Last night I lay with my father. We will get him drunk with wine again tonight; then you go in and lie with him, so that through our father we may keep his line alive." 35 That night they also gave their father wine to drink, and the younger rose and lay with him; and he did not know when she lay down or when she rose. 36 So Lot's two daughters conceived by their own father. 37 The firstborn bore a son and called his name Moab.[p] He is the father of the Moabites to this day. 38 The younger also bore a son and called his name Ben-ammi.[q] He is the father of the Ammonites to this day.

Notes

- a (19:1) The city gate was the place of business, courts, and civic life. Sitting there may suggest Lot held some standing in the city.
- b (19:5) "Know" here means sexual relations, as in 4:1 and 19:8. The demand was for gang rape of strangers who were under a host's protection, a gross violation of hospitality. Compare Judges 19:22–25.
- c (19:8) Literally "the shadow of my beams." Lot's offer of his daughters is shocking; the narrative records it without approval, and the later events of 19:30–38 turn on the same daughters.
- d (19:9) Literally "and he judges, judging," a Hebrew way of stressing the verb.
- e (19:11) Hebrew sanverim, a rare word used only here and in 2 Kings 6:18. It may mean a sudden dazzling or a confusion of sight.
- f (19:14) Or "who had married." The Hebrew can mean either; 19:8 says the daughters had not known a man, which suggests engagement.
- g (19:15) Hebrew awon, "iniquity," which also means its consequence, "punishment." The Septuagint reads "the iniquities of the city."
- h (19:17) The Hebrew has "he said." The Septuagint reads "they said," as do some other ancient versions.
- i (19:18) Or "my Lord." As in 18:3, the Hebrew vowels read "Lord" (Adonai), but the consonants allow "my lords."
- j (19:21) Literally "I have lifted up your face in this matter also," an idiom for granting a request.
- k (19:22) Zoar sounds like mits'ar, "a small thing" (19:20). Its earlier name was Bela (14:2).

- l (19:24) The repetition "Yahweh ... from Yahweh" is unusual. Some early Christian writers read it as two divine persons; others see a Hebrew way of saying "from himself."
- m (19:26) Jesus recalls this in Luke 17:32. The salt formations near the Dead Sea gave rise to local traditions about the pillar (Wisdom of Solomon 10:7; Josephus, Antiquities 1.203).
- n (19:31) Or "on the earth." The daughters may have thought the whole world had been destroyed.
- o (19:33) In the Masoretic Text the word "when she got up" carries a special scribal dot over one letter, an old mark of doubt or comment, found in only a handful of places in the Torah.
- p (19:37) Moab sounds like me'av, "from father." The Septuagint adds "saying, 'He is from my father.'"
- q (19:38) Ben-ammi means "son of my kin (or people)." The Septuagint reads Amman and adds "saying, 'Son of my family.'"

Chapter 20

1 Abraham moved on from there into the Negev country and lived
between Kadesh and Shur. While he was staying as a foreigner in
Gerar, 2 Abraham said of Sarah his wife, "She is my sister." So Abim-
elech[a] king of Gerar sent and took Sarah. 3 God came to Abimelech in
a dream in the night and told him, "You are about to die because of the
woman you have taken, for she is a man's wife."[b] 4 Now Abimelech
had not come near her. He said, "Lord, will you kill a nation even
though it is innocent?[c] 5 Was it not he who told me, 'She is my sister'?
And she too said, 'He is my brother.' I acted with an innocent heart[d]
and guiltless hands." 6 God said to him in the dream, "Yes, I know
that you did this with a heart of integrity, and I myself kept you from
sinning against me. That is why I did not let you touch her. 7 Now
give the man back his wife. He is a prophet;[e] he will pray on your
behalf, and you will live. But if you do not give her back, be sure that
you will die, you and everyone belonging to you."
8 Early next morning Abimelech summoned all his officials and told
them everything, and the men were terrified. 9 Then Abimelech called
Abraham and said to him, "What is this you have done to us? What
offense have I committed against you, that you brought upon me and
my kingdom a great sin? You have done to me deeds that should never
be done." 10 And Abimelech said to Abraham, "What did you have in

mind,[f] that you did this thing?" 11 Abraham said, "I thought, 'Surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me because of my wife.' 12 Besides, she really is my sister, the daughter of my father though not the daughter of my mother, and she became my wife. 13 When God caused me to wander[g] from my father's house, I said to her, 'This is the kindness you must show me: at every place we come to, say of me, "He is my brother."'"
14 Abimelech took sheep and cattle, with male and female servants, and gave them to Abraham; he also gave Sarah, his wife, back to him. 15 And Abimelech said, "Look, my land is before you. Settle wherever is good in your eyes." 16 To Sarah he said, "Look, I am giving your brother a thousand pieces of silver,[h] about 25 pounds. This is a covering of the eyes[i] for you in the sight of all who are with you, and with everyone you are set right."[j] 17 Then Abraham prayed to God, and God healed Abimelech, his wife, and his female slaves, so that they bore children. 18 For Yahweh had closed up every womb in the house of Abimelech because of Sarah, Abraham's wife.

Notes

- a (20:2) Abimelech means "my father is king." It may be a royal title as well as a name (compare 26:1).
- b (20:3) Literally "she is married to a husband (ba'al)."
- c (20:4) Literally "a righteous nation." Abimelech echoes Abraham's plea for Sodom (18:23–25). The Septuagint reads "a nation that sins in ignorance and is righteous."
- d (20:5) Literally "in the integrity of my heart."
- e (20:7) The first use of "prophet" (navi) in the Bible. Here the prophet's role is to pray for others.
- f (20:10) Literally "What did you see?"
- g (20:13) The Hebrew verb is plural, which might suggest "the gods made me wander." But Elohim, "God," is sometimes used with plural verbs, and Abraham may be speaking in terms a foreign king would understand.
- h (20:16) Hebrew "a thousand of silver," that is, a thousand shekels, about 25 pounds (11.5 kilograms), counting a shekel as about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); weight standards varied. The text keeps the literal "pieces of silver" and gives the weight alongside.
- i (20:16) The idiom is uncertain. It probably means the payment publicly clears Sarah's honor, so that others will "cover their eyes" to the matter. The Septuagint reads "the price of your face (or honor)."

- j (20:16) Or “you are vindicated” or “you are set right.” The Hebrew nokachat is difficult. The Septuagint reads “speak the truth in all things.”

Chapter 21

1 Yahweh visited[a] Sarah just as he had said; Yahweh did for Sarah
exactly what he had promised. 2 Sarah conceived and bore Abraham
a son in his old age, at the set time that God had told him. 3 Abraham
called the name of his son who was born to him, whom Sarah bore
him, Isaac. 4 And Abraham circumcised Isaac his son when he was
eight days old, as God had commanded him. 5 Abraham was a hundred
years old when Isaac his son was born to him. 6 Sarah said, “God has
brought me laughter; all who hear of it will laugh with me.”[b] 7 And
she said, “Who would have said to Abraham that Sarah would nurse
children? Yet I have borne him a son in his old age.”
8 The child grew and was weaned, and on the day of Isaac’s weaning
Abraham gave a great feast. 9 But Sarah saw the son of Hagar the
Egyptian, whom she had borne to Abraham, laughing.[c] 10 She said to
Abraham, “Send away this slave woman and her son, for this slave
woman’s son shall not share the inheritance with my son Isaac.” 11
The matter was very displeasing[d] to Abraham because of his son. 12
But God told Abraham, “Do not be troubled over the boy and your
slave girl. Do whatever Sarah tells you, for your line will be traced
through Isaac.[e] 13 But I will make a nation of the slave woman’s son
too, since he is your offspring.”
14 Early next morning Abraham took bread and a skin of water and
handed them to Hagar, setting them on her shoulder together with
the child,[f] and sent her off. She left and roamed the wilderness of
Beersheba. 15 When the skin ran dry, she left the child under a shrub.
16 She went and sat down at a distance, about a bowshot off, because
she said, “Let me not look on the death of the child.” So she sat facing
him, raised her voice, and wept.[g] 17 God heard the voice of the boy,
and the angel of God called to Hagar from heaven and said to her,
“What troubles you, Hagar? Do not be afraid, for God has heard the
voice of the boy where he is. 18 Up! Raise the boy and take a firm hold
of him, for of him I will make a great nation.” 19 God opened her eyes,

and she saw a well of water. She went, filled the water skin, and gave the boy a drink. 20 God stayed with the boy as he grew. He made his home in the wilderness and became a skilled archer.[h] 21 He lived in the wilderness of Paran, and his mother took a wife for him from the land of Egypt.

22 At that time Abimelech and Phicol the commander of his army[i] said to Abraham, "God is with you in all that you do. 23 So now swear to me here by God that you will not deal falsely with me or with my children or my descendants. As I have shown you loyal kindness, so you will show it to me and to the land where you have lived as a foreigner." 24 Abraham said, "I swear it." 25 Abraham rebuked Abimelech over a well that Abimelech's men had taken by force. 26 Abimelech answered, "I do not know who has done this. You never told me, and I heard of it only today." 27 So Abraham took sheep and cattle and gave them to Abimelech, and the two of them made a covenant. 28 Abraham set apart seven ewe lambs of the flock by themselves. 29 Abimelech asked Abraham, "Why have you put these seven ewe lambs off by themselves?" 30 He said, "Accept these seven ewe lambs from my hand, so that they will be my witness that I dug this well." 31 For this reason the place was named Beersheba,[j] because the two of them took an oath there. 32 After making a covenant at Beersheba, Abimelech and Phicol his army commander left and went back to Philistine country.[k] 33 Abraham planted a tamarisk tree[l] in Beersheba, and there he called on the name of Yahweh, El Olam.[m] 34 And Abraham lived as a foreigner in the land of the Philistines for many days.

Notes

- a (21:1) Hebrew paqad, "to visit," "to attend to," or "to take note of," often of God acting to keep a promise.
- b (21:6) Or "will laugh at me." The Hebrew can express shared joy or mocking surprise. The Septuagint reads "will rejoice with me."
- c (21:9) Hebrew metsacheq, from the root of Isaac's name. It can mean playing, laughing, or mocking (compare Galatians 4:29). The Septuagint adds "with Isaac her son," and Brenton renders the verb "sporting."
- d (21:11) Literally "evil in the eyes of Abraham, very."
- e (21:12) Literally "in Isaac seed will be called to you." Quoted in Romans 9:7 and Hebrews 11:18.

- f (21:14) The Hebrew order is unclear: either the food and water, or the boy too, are placed on her shoulder. Ishmael was then a teenager (16:16; 21:5). The Septuagint reads "he put the child on her shoulder."
- g (21:16) The Septuagint reads "and the child cried aloud and wept," which leads into 21:17, where God hears "the voice of the boy."
- h (21:20) The Hebrew rovah qashat is unusual, perhaps "a young bowman" or "one who shoots with the bow."
- i (21:22) The Septuagint adds "Ochozath his friend" (Ahuzzath) here and in 21:32, a name the Hebrew gives only in 26:26.
- j (21:31) Beersheba means both "well of seven" and "well of the oath," since the Hebrew words for "seven" and "swear" share a root. The Septuagint translates it "the Well of the Oath."
- k (21:32) The Philistines are known from records as arriving on this coast around 1200 BC. The name here may be used for earlier people of the same region, or it may update the name for later readers.
- l (21:33) Hebrew eshel, "tamarisk," a hardy tree of the Negev. Brenton's Septuagint reads "planted a field."
- m (21:33) Hebrew El Olam, "God of eternity" or "the Everlasting God."

Chapter 22

1 Some time afterward God put Abraham to the test.[a] "Abraham!" he
called. "Here I am," Abraham answered. 2 God said, "Take your son,
your one and only son,[b] Isaac, whom you love, and travel to the land
of Moriah.[c] Offer him up as a burnt offering,[d] on one of the mountains
that I will tell you." 3 So Abraham rose early in the morning, saddled
his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his
son. He split the wood for the burnt offering, then got up and went to
the place that God had told him. 4 On the third day Abraham looked
up and saw the place far off. 5 Then Abraham said to his young men,
"Stay here with the donkey. The boy and I will go over there. We will
worship, and we will come back to you."[e] 6 Abraham took the wood
for the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son. He took in his hand
the fire[f] and the knife, and the two of them walked on together. 7 Isaac
said to Abraham his father, "My father!" And he said, "Here I am, my
son." He said, "Here is the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb
for a burnt offering?" 8 Abraham said, "God will see to[g] the lamb for
a burnt offering himself, my son." And the two of them walked on
together.

9 When they came to the place that God had told him, Abraham built
the altar there and arranged the wood. He bound[h] Isaac his son and
laid him on the altar, on top of the wood. 10 Then Abraham reached
out his hand and took the knife to slaughter his son. 11 But the angel
of Yahweh called to him from heaven and said, "Abraham, Abraham!"
And he said, "Here I am." 12 He said, "Do not lay your hand on the boy
or do anything to him, for now I know that you fear God, since you
have not held back your son, your only son, from me." 13 Abraham
looked up, and there behind him[i] was a ram, caught by its horns
in a thicket.[j] He went, took the ram, and offered it up as a burnt
offering instead of his son. 14 So Abraham called the name of that place
"Yahweh Yireh,"[k] as it is said to this day, "On the mountain of Yahweh
it will be seen."[l]
15 The angel of Yahweh called to Abraham a second time from heaven
16 and said, "I have sworn by myself, declares Yahweh: because you
have done this thing and have not withheld your son, your only son,
17 I will richly bless you and make your descendants as countless as
the stars in the sky and the sand along the shore. Your descendants
will take hold of the gate[m] of their foes, 18 and in your offspring all
the nations of the earth will be blessed,[n] because you have obeyed
my voice." 19 Abraham went back to his young men; they rose and
traveled together to Beersheba, and Abraham settled in Beersheba.
20 After these things Abraham was told, "Milcah too has borne
children to your brother Nahor: 21 Uz his firstborn, Buz his brother,
Kemuel the father of Aram, 22 Chesed, Hazo, Pildash, Jidlaph, and
Bethuel." 23 Bethuel became the father of Rebekah.[o] These eight Milcah
bore to Nahor, Abraham's brother. 24 His concubine, whose name was
Reumah, also bore Tebah, Gaham, Tahash, and Maacah.

Notes

- a (22:1) Hebrew nissah, "tested" or "proved." The narrator tells the reader at the start that this is a test. Jewish tradition calls this chapter the Aqedah, "the Binding" (22:9). Compare Hebrews 11:17–19 and James 2:21–23.
- b (22:2) Hebrew yachid, "only" or "unique." Ishmael had been sent away, so Isaac was the only son left with Abraham and the only son of the promise. The Septuagint reads "the beloved one."

- c (22:2) 2 Chronicles 3:1 identifies Mount Moriah as the site of Solomon's temple in Jerusalem. The Septuagint reads "the high land." The name is linked by sound with ra'ah, "to see," which runs through the chapter (22:4, 8, 13, 14).
- d (22:2) Hebrew olah, literally "that which goes up," an offering wholly burned on the altar.
- e (22:5) The Hebrew verbs are plural: "we will come back." Hebrews 11:19 sees here Abraham's faith that God could raise the dead.
- f (22:6) Probably a pot of coals for lighting the altar fire.
- g (22:8) Literally "God will see for himself the lamb." In Hebrew "see to" means "provide." The phrase anticipates the name in 22:14.
- h (22:9) Hebrew aqad, used only here in the Bible, the source of the Jewish name for the passage.
- i (22:13) Hebrew achar, "behind." Some Hebrew manuscripts and several ancient versions read echad, "a (single) ram," which differs by one similar letter.
- j (22:13) The Septuagint takes the Hebrew word sevakh, "thicket," as a name: "a plant of Sabec."
- k (22:14) Hebrew Yahweh yir'eh, "Yahweh will see," that is, "Yahweh will provide" (compare 22:8). Brenton's Septuagint reads "The Lord hath seen."
- l (22:14) Or "On the mountain Yahweh will be seen (or will appear)," or "On the mountain of Yahweh it will be provided." The Hebrew can be vowelled several ways.
- m (22:17) The city gate stands for the city itself and its power. The Septuagint reads "the cities of their enemies."
- n (22:18) Or "will bless themselves" (compare 12:3). The verb form here differs from 12:3 and more naturally means "bless themselves." Acts 3:25 quotes it as a promise to all peoples.
- o (22:23) This note about Rebekah prepares for chapter 24.

Chapter 23

1 Sarah lived 127 years; these were the years of Sarah's life.[a] 2 Sarah
died in Kiriath-arba[b] (Hebron) in Canaan, and Abraham came to
lament over Sarah and to weep for her.
3 Then Abraham rose from beside his dead and spoke to the sons of
Heth:[c] 4 "I am a foreigner and a resident among you.[d] Give me property
among you for a burial place, so that I may bury my dead out of my
sight." 5 The sons of Heth answered Abraham, 6 "Hear us, my lord. You
are a mighty prince[e] among us. Bury your dead in the choicest of our
tombs. None of us will withhold his tomb from you for burying your
dead." 7 Abraham rose and bowed down to the people of the land, the
sons of Heth. 8 He said to them, "If you are willing for me to bury my

dead out of my sight, hear me and plead for me with Ephron son of Zohar, [9] to let me have the cave of Machpelah[f] that he owns, at the far end of his field. Let him sell it to me at full value here among you, to be mine as a burial site."

[10] Now Ephron was sitting among the sons of Heth, and Ephron the Hittite answered Abraham in the hearing of the sons of Heth, of all who went in at the gate of his city: [11] "No, my lord, hear me. I give you the field, and I give you the cave that is in it. In the sight of my people I give it to you. Bury your dead."[g] [12] Then Abraham bowed down before the people of the land. [13] and said to Ephron in the people's hearing, "Please, listen to me. I will pay for the field. Accept the money from me, so I can bury my dead there." [14] Ephron answered Abraham, [15] "My lord, hear me. A piece of land worth about ten pounds[h] of silver, what is that between you and me? Bury your dead." [16] Abraham agreed with Ephron and weighed out for him the silver he had named in the hearing of the sons of Heth, about ten pounds of silver by the merchants' standard weight.[i]

[17] So the field of Ephron in Machpelah, facing Mamre, the field with the cave in it and all the trees in the field throughout its whole boundary, passed [18] as Abraham's possession in the sight of the sons of Heth, in front of all who entered the gate of his city. [19] After this Abraham buried his wife Sarah in the cave of the field at Machpelah, opposite Mamre, that is, Hebron, in the land of Canaan. [20] The field and the cave in it passed from the sons of Heth to Abraham as property for a burial place.[j]

Notes

- a (23:1) Literally "The life of Sarah was one hundred years, and twenty years, and seven years; these were the years of Sarah's life." Sarah is the only woman in the Bible whose age at death is given.
- b (23:2) Kiriath-arba means "city of four," perhaps four clans or four settlements (compare Joshua 14:15). The Septuagint adds "which is in the valley."
- c (23:3) The sons of Heth (10:15) are a local Canaanite people, elsewhere called Hittites; they were probably not the same as the Hittite empire of Anatolia.
- d (23:4) Hebrew ger wetoshav, "a foreigner and a settler," someone living in the land without owning any of it. This burial cave becomes the first piece of the promised land Abraham owns.

- e (23:6) Literally “a prince of God,” a Hebrew way of saying “a very great prince.” The Septuagint reads “a king from God.”
- f (23:9) Machpelah may mean “double.” The Septuagint translates it “the double cave.” The traditional site is in Hebron.
- g (23:11) The courteous offer of a gift was part of the bargaining. Abraham insists on a purchase so that his ownership could not later be disputed.
- h (23:15) Hebrew “four hundred shekels of silver.” A shekel was a weight, not yet a coin; counting it as about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), 400 shekels is about 10 pounds (4.6 kilograms). Weight standards varied from place to place and period to period. It was a very high price. The Septuagint reads “didrachms.”
- i (23:16) Hebrew “four hundred shekels of silver” (about 10 pounds, 4.6 kilograms; see the note on 23:15), literally “passing to the merchant,” silver of standard, accepted weight.
- j (23:20) The cave became the family tomb of Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Leah, and Jacob (25:9; 49:29–32; 50:13).

Chapter 24

1 Abraham was old, well along in years, and Yahweh had blessed
Abraham in all things. 2 Abraham said to his servant, the oldest of
his household, who managed all that he had, “Please put your hand
under my thigh,[a] 3 and I will make you swear by Yahweh, the God
of heaven and the God of the earth, that you will not take a wife for
my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, among whom I live, 4
but you will go to my country and to my relatives and take a wife
for my son Isaac.” 5 The servant asked him, “What if the woman will
not agree to come with me to this land? Should I then lead your son
back to the country you left?” 6 Abraham said to him, “Be careful that
you do not take my son back there. 7 Yahweh, the God of heaven, who
took me from my father’s house and from the land of my birth, who
pledged to me by oath, ‘To your offspring I will give this land’—he
will send his angel before you, and you will take a wife for my son
from there. 8 But if the woman will not agree to come with you, you
will be released[b] from this oath to me. Just never lead my son back
there.” 9 So the servant put his hand under the thigh of Abraham his
master and swore to him concerning this matter.
10 The servant took ten of his master’s camels and left, with all sorts
of fine gifts from his master in hand. He made his way to Aram-
naharaim,[c] to Nahor’s city. 11 He made the camels kneel down outside

the city by the well of water at evening, the time when the women
go out to draw water. 12 And he said, "Yahweh, God of my master
Abraham, please make things go well for me today, and show loyal
love[d] to my master Abraham. 13 Look, I am standing by the spring of
water, and the daughters of the men of the city are coming out to
draw water. 14 Let the young woman to whom I say, 'Please lower your
jar so that I may drink,' and who says, 'Drink, and I will water your
camels too,' be the one you have appointed for your servant Isaac. By
this I will know that you have shown loyal love to my master."
15 He had not yet finished speaking when Rebekah came out, with her
jar on her shoulder. She was born to Bethuel son of Milcah, the wife
of Nahor, Abraham's brother. 16 The young woman was very beautiful
to look at, a virgin;[e] no man had known her. She went down to the
spring, filled her jar, and came up. 17 The servant hurried to meet her
and said, "Please give me a little sip of water from your jar." 18 "Drink,
my lord," she said. She quickly let her jar down onto her hand and
gave him water to drink. 19 When she had finished giving him a drink,
she said, "I will draw for your camels too, until they have finished
drinking." 20 She quickly tipped her jar out into the trough and hurried
back to the well to draw more, drawing enough for every one of his
camels.[f] 21 The man gazed at her in silence, waiting to learn whether
Yahweh had made his journey successful or not.
22 When the camels were done drinking, the man brought out a gold
nose ring weighing about a fifth of an ounce,[g] and for her arms
two gold bracelets weighing about four ounces. 23 and said, "Whose
daughter are you? Please tell me, is there room in your father's house
for us to spend the night?" 24 She said to him, "I am the daughter of
Bethuel son of Milcah, whom she bore to Nahor." 25 And she added,
"There is ample straw and feed at our house, and a place to stay the
night." 26 The man bowed his head and worshiped Yahweh, 27 and said,
"Blessed be Yahweh, the God of my master Abraham, who has not
withdrawn his loyal love and his faithfulness[h] from my master. As
for me, Yahweh has led me on the way to the house of my master's
relatives."

28 Then the young woman ran and told her mother's household[i] about
these things. 29 Rebekah had a brother whose name was Laban. Laban
ran out to the man at the spring. 30 He had seen the nose ring and the
bracelets on his sister's arms, and had heard Rebekah his sister tell
what the man had said to her. So he went out to the man and found
him still standing by the camels at the spring. 31 He said, "Come in,
you who are blessed by Yahweh. Why are you standing outside? I
have prepared the house and a place for the camels." 32 So the man
came into the house. Laban[j] unloaded the camels and gave straw and
fodder to the camels, and water to wash his feet and the feet of the
men who were with him. 33 Then food was set before him to eat, but
he said, "I will not eat until I have told my errand." He said, "Speak."
34 So he said, "I am Abraham's servant. 35 Yahweh has blessed my
master richly, and he has grown wealthy. Yahweh has given him
sheep and cattle, silver and gold, menservants and maidservants,
camels and donkeys. 36 Sarah, my master's wife, bore my master a son
after she had grown old,[k] and he has given him everything he owns.
37 My master made me take an oath: 'You shall not take a wife for
my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, in whose land I am
living, 38 but you shall go to the house of my father and to my family,
and you shall take a wife for my son.' 39 I asked my master, 'What if
the woman will not come with me?' 40 But he said to me, 'Yahweh, in
whose presence I have walked, will send his angel with you and give
you success on your journey. You will take a wife for my son from
my family and from the house of my father. 41 You will be released
from my oath[l] if you go to my kin; even if they refuse you, you will
be released from my oath.'
42 "When I came to the spring today, I said, 'Yahweh, God of my
master Abraham, if you are indeed making my journey successful, the
journey I am on, 43 see, I am waiting here by the spring. When a young
woman[m] comes out to draw, and I ask her, "Please give me a little
water to drink from your jar," 44 and who says to me, "Drink, and I will
draw for your camels too," let her be the woman whom Yahweh has
appointed for my master's son.' 45 "Before I had finished speaking in
my heart, there was Rebekah coming out with her jar on her shoulder.

She went down to the spring and drew water. I said to her, ‘Please let
me drink.’ 46 She quickly lowered her jar from her shoulder and said,
‘Drink, and I will water your camels too.’ So I drank, and she watered
the camels also. 47 Then I asked her, ‘Whose daughter are you?’ She
said, ‘The daughter of Bethuel son of Nahor, whom Milcah bore to
him.’ So I put the ring on her nose and the bracelets on her wrists. 48
I bowed my head and worshiped Yahweh. I blessed Yahweh, the God
of my master Abraham, who had guided me along the way of truth
to obtain the daughter of my master’s kinsman[n] for his son. 49 Now, if
you are willing to deal with my master in loyal love and faithfulness,
tell me; and if not, tell me, so that I may turn to the right hand or to
the left.”
50 Then Laban and Bethuel[o] answered, “This thing comes from
Yahweh. We cannot speak to you bad or good.[p] 51 Look, Rebekah is
before you. Take her and go, and let her be the wife of your master’s
son, as Yahweh has spoken.” 52 When Abraham’s servant heard what
they said, he bowed to the ground before Yahweh. 53 Then the servant
brought out objects of silver, objects of gold, and garments, and gave
them to Rebekah; he also gave precious things to her brother and to
her mother.
54 Then he and his companions ate and drank and stayed the night. In
the morning when they rose, he said, “Let me go back to my master.”
55 Her brother and her mother said, “Let the young woman stay with
us a few days, ten perhaps.[q] After that she may go.” 56 He said to them,
“Do not hold me up, now that Yahweh has prospered my journey.
Send me off, so that I may go to my master.” 57 They answered, “We
will call the girl and ask what she wants.”[r] 58 So they called Rebekah
and said to her, “Will you go with this man?” She said, “I will go.” 59 So
they sent away Rebekah their sister and her nurse,[s] with Abraham’s
servant and his men. 60 They blessed Rebekah, saying to her, “Our
sister, may you become thousands of myriads, and may your offspring
take possession of the gate of those who hate them.” 61 Rebekah and
her young women rose, rode on the camels, and followed after the
man. Thus the servant took Rebekah and departed.

62 Now Isaac had come from[t] the way to Beer-lahai-roi, for he was
living in the region of the Negev. 63 Isaac went out to walk[u] in the field
toward evening. He looked up and saw camels coming. 64 Rebekah
looked up, and when she saw Isaac, she slipped down from the camel
65 and asked the servant, "Who is that man walking in the field toward
us?" The servant answered, "That is my master." She took her veil and
covered herself with it. 66 The servant told Isaac all the things he had
done. 67 Then Isaac brought her into the tent of Sarah his mother,[v] and
he took Rebekah, and she became his wife, and he loved her. So Isaac
was comforted after his mother's death.

Notes

- a (24:2) An oath gesture, found again in 47:29. "Thigh" may be a polite word for the reproductive organs, tying the oath to the family line and the covenant sign of circumcision.
- b (24:8) Literally "clean" or "innocent," released from guilt if the oath is not fulfilled.
- c (24:10) Aram-naharaim means "Aram of the two rivers," the region of the upper Euphrates. The Septuagint reads "Mesopotamia."
- d (24:12) Hebrew chesed, steadfast, loyal love within a relationship of commitment. The word is a key to this chapter (24:14, 27, 49).
- e (24:16) Hebrew betulah, a young woman of marriageable age; the clause that follows makes clear that she was a virgin. In 24:43 a different word, almah, "young woman," is used.
- f (24:20) A camel can drink a great deal after a journey. Drawing for ten camels was a heavy task, a sign of Rebekah's generosity and strength.
- g (24:22) Hebrew "a beka (half a shekel) its weight," about a fifth of an ounce (5.7 grams), and bracelets of "ten shekels of gold their weight," about 4 ounces (115 grams), counting a shekel as about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); weight standards varied. The Septuagint reads "golden earrings of a drachm weight." 24:47 makes clear the ring was for her nose.
- h (24:27) Hebrew chesed we'emet, "loyal love and faithfulness (or truth)," a pair often used of God (Exodus 34:6).
- i (24:28) Literally "her mother's house," perhaps the women's quarters, or a sign that her father was no longer living or not the head of the house. Bethuel is barely mentioned (but see 24:50).
- j (24:32) The Hebrew has only "he unloaded." Laban is the most likely subject, though some read it as the servant.
- k (24:36) Literally "after her old age." The Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to read "his old age."
- l (24:41) Hebrew alah, "curse," the curse that would fall on someone who broke an oath. The Septuagint reads "my curse."

- m (24:43) Hebrew almah, “young woman,” the word used in Isaiah 7:14. Here it describes Rebekah, whom 24:16 calls a virgin.
- n (24:48) Literally “brother.” Rebekah was the granddaughter of Abraham’s brother Nahor.
- o (24:50) The mention of Bethuel here is surprising, since elsewhere Laban and his mother act for the family (24:28, 53, 55). Some scholars think the name was added, or that it means another member of the household. Josephus says Bethuel was dead.
- p (24:50) An idiom meaning “We can say nothing at all against it.”
- q (24:55) Literally “days or ten,” an unusual phrase that may mean “a year or ten months,” or “a few days, about ten.” The Septuagint reads “about ten days.”
- r (24:57) Literally “ask her mouth.” The family seeks her consent.
- s (24:59) Deborah, according to 35:8. The Septuagint reads “her goods.”
- t (24:62) The Hebrew is awkward: literally “Isaac came from coming (to) Beer-lahai-roi.” The Septuagint reads “Isaac went through the wilderness to the well of the vision.” Beer-lahai-roi is the well where God met Hagar (16:14).
- u (24:63) Hebrew lasuach, a rare verb of uncertain meaning. Proposals include “to walk,” “to meditate,” “to pray,” and “to lament.” The Septuagint reads “to meditate,” and Jewish tradition took this as the origin of the afternoon prayer.
- v (24:67) The Hebrew reads “into the tent Sarah his mother,” which looks like a scribal gloss or shortened phrase. The sense is clear: Rebekah takes the place of honor that had been Sarah’s.

Chapter 25

1 Abraham took another wife, whose name was Keturah.[a] 2 She bore
to him Zimran and Jokshan, Medan and Midian, Ishbak and Shuah.
3 Jokshan was the father of Sheba and of Dedan. The sons of Dedan
were Asshurim, Letushim, and Leummim. 4 The sons of Midian[b] were
Ephah, Epher, Hanoch, Abida, and Eldaah. All these were the descendants of Keturah. 5 Abraham gave all that he had to Isaac. 6 But to the
sons of his concubines[c] Abraham gave gifts during his lifetime, and
he sent them off to the east country, away from his son Isaac.
7 These are the days of the years of Abraham’s life: 175 years. 8 Abra-
ham breathed his last and died at a good old age, old and satisfied,[d]
and he was gathered to his people.[e] 9 Isaac and Ishmael his sons buried
him in the cave of Machpelah, in the field of Ephron son of Zohar the
Hittite, facing Mamre, 10 the field that Abraham bought from the sons
of Heth. There Abraham was buried, with Sarah his wife. 11 After the

death of Abraham, God blessed Isaac his son. And Isaac settled near Beer-lahai-roi.

12 These are the generations[f] of Ishmael, Abraham's son, whom Hagar
the Egyptian, Sarah's slave woman, bore to Abraham. 13 These are the
names of Ishmael's sons, named in the order of their births: Nebaioth,
Ishmael's firstborn; then Kedar, Adbeel, and Mibsam, 14 Mishma,
Dumah, and Massa, 15 Hadad, Tema, Jetur, Naphish, and Kedemah. 16
These are the sons of Ishmael, and these are their names, by their
villages and their encampments,[g] twelve chieftains according to their
tribes.[h] 17 Ishmael lived 137 years in all. Then he breathed his last and
died and was gathered to his people. 18 His descendants lived in the
territory from Havilah to Shur, which lies east of Egypt on the way
to Assyria. He settled at odds with[i] all his kin.

19 These are the generations of Isaac, Abraham's son: Abraham
fathered Isaac. 20 Isaac was forty years of age when he took Rebekah
as wife—daughter of Bethuel the Aramean from Paddan-aram,[j] and
sister of Laban the Aramean.

21 Isaac prayed to Yahweh for his wife, because she was barren.
Yahweh answered his prayer, and Rebekah his wife conceived. 22 The
children struggled together[k] within her, and she said, "If it is like
this, why am I alive?"[l] So she went to ask Yahweh. 23 Yahweh said to
her, "Two nations are in your womb, and two peoples will separate
from your body. One people will be stronger than the other, and the
older will serve the younger."[m] 24 When her days to give birth were
completed, there were twins in her womb. 25 The first came out red,[n]
his whole body like a hairy cloak, so they called his name Esau.[o] 26
After this his brother emerged, his hand grasping the heel of Esau,
and he was named Jacob.[p] Isaac was sixty years old at the time she
bore them.

27 The boys grew, and Esau became a man skilled in hunting, a man of
the field, but Jacob was a quiet man,[q] dwelling in tents. 28 Isaac favored
Esau, for game was to his liking,[r] but Rebekah favored Jacob. 29 Once
when Jacob was cooking stew, Esau came in from the open country,
and he was exhausted. 30 Esau said to Jacob, "Please let me swallow
some of the red stuff, this red stuff, for I am exhausted." Therefore he

was named Edom.[s] 31 Jacob said, "First sell me your birthright."[t] 32 Esau said, "Look, I am about to die. What use is a birthright to me?" 33 Jacob said, "First give me your oath." So Esau gave his oath and sold Jacob his birthright. 34 Jacob gave Esau bread and a stew of lentils; he ate and drank, rose, and left. Thus Esau despised his birthright.[u]

Notes

- a (25:1) Or "had taken." The Hebrew does not say when this marriage took place; it may have been during Sarah's lifetime. 1 Chronicles 1:32 calls Keturah a concubine. Keturah may mean "incense," fitting her descendants' links with the Arabian incense trade.
- b (25:4) Midian became the ancestor of the Midianites, among whom Moses later lived and married (Exodus 2:15–22).
- c (25:6) Probably Hagar and Keturah.
- d (25:8) Hebrew zaqen wesave'a, "old and satisfied (or full)." The Septuagint reads "full of days," and some other ancient witnesses also add "of days," as in 35:29.
- e (25:8) An expression for joining one's ancestors in death, distinct from burial (25:9). It may reflect a belief in continued existence with one's forebears.
- f (25:12) Hebrew toledot, "generations" or "family history," the heading that divides Genesis into sections (2:4; 5:1; 6:9; 10:1; 11:10, 27; 25:12, 19).
- g (25:16) Hebrew tirah, a walled camp or circle of tents used by nomads.
- h (25:16) The twelve chieftains fulfill the promise of 17:20. Several names, such as Kedar, Tema, Dumah, and Nebaioth, are known from Assyrian and Arabian records as North Arabian tribes or oases.
- i (25:18) Or "to the east of" or "alongside," as in 16:12. The Hebrew literally reads "he fell upon the face of." The Septuagint reads "he dwelt in the presence of all his brothers."
- j (25:20) Paddan-aram probably means "field (or plain) of Aram," the area around Haran. The Septuagint reads "Syrian Mesopotamia."
- k (25:22) Hebrew ratsats, literally "crushed one another," a violent word. The Septuagint reads "leaped."
- l (25:22) Literally "If so, why this I?" The Hebrew is abrupt. It may mean "Why is this happening to me?" or "Why do I go on living?" The Syriac is reported to read "why do I live?"
- m (25:23) The Hebrew rav ya'avod tsa'ir is short and can be read either way: "the older will serve the younger" or, with poetic word order, "the older the younger will serve." Paul quotes the usual sense in Romans 9:12. The oracle concerns nations, Israel and Edom, as well as two brothers.
- n (25:25) Hebrew admoni, "reddish," a play on Edom (25:30).
- o (25:25) The name Esau is not explained in the text. "Hairy" (se'ar) plays on Seir, the hill country where Edom later lived (32:3).

- p (25:26) Jacob (Ya'aqov) sounds like aqev, "heel." The name may mean "may God protect," but here it is linked with grasping the heel, and later with supplanting (27:36).
- q (25:27) Hebrew tam, the word used of Job (Job 1:1), usually meaning "blameless" or "whole." Here it may mean "mild," "settled," or "civilized," in contrast with the hunter. The Septuagint reads "a simple man."
- r (25:28) Literally "because game was in his mouth."
- s (25:30) Edom means "red." The Hebrew repeats "the red, this red," showing Esau's hungry haste.
- t (25:31) The birthright was the firstborn son's right to a double share of the inheritance and to leadership of the family (Deuteronomy 21:17).
- u (25:34) Hebrews 12:16 uses this scene as a warning against treating holy things lightly.

Chapter 26

1 Now a famine came upon the land, another besides the first famine
in Abraham's days. And Isaac went to Gerar, to Abimelech, king of
the Philistines.[a] 2 There Yahweh showed himself to Isaac and said, "Do
not go down into Egypt. Stay in the land I name to you. 3 Live as a
sojourner in this land, and I will be with you and will bless you. To
you and your descendants I will give all these territories, and I will
carry out the oath I swore to your father Abraham. 4 I will make your
descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven and grant to them
all these territories, and through your descendants every nation on
earth will find blessing,[b] 5 since Abraham listened to my voice and
kept what I entrusted to him: my commands, my decrees, and my
teachings."[c]
6 So Isaac lived on in Gerar. 7 The local men asked about his wife, and
he told them, "She is my sister." He was afraid to call her his wife, for
he thought, "The men here may kill me to get Rebekah," because she
was lovely to look at. 8 After he had lived there many days, Abimelech
king of the Philistines happened to look down through a window, and
there was Isaac fondling[d] his wife Rebekah. 9 Abimelech summoned
Isaac and said, "She is your wife, then! Why did you tell us, 'She is
my sister'?" Isaac answered, "I thought I would lose my life on her
account." 10 Abimelech said, "What have you done to us? Any one of
the people could soon have slept with your wife, and you would have

laid guilt upon us." 11 Then Abimelech gave an order to all the people:
"Anyone who lays a hand on this man or on his wife shall be put
to death."
12 Isaac planted crops in that land, and that same year he harvested
a hundredfold,[e] because Yahweh blessed him. 13 He grew great, and
went on growing greater, until he was a man of great wealth. 14 He
owned sheep and cattle and many servants, and the Philistines grew
jealous of him. 15 All the wells that his father's servants had dug back
in Abraham's lifetime, the Philistines had blocked and filled up with
dirt. 16 Abimelech told Isaac, "Leave us. You have grown far too strong
for us."
17 So Isaac left and pitched his tents in the Gerar valley[f] and lived there.
18 Isaac dug again the wells that had been dug in the days of his father
Abraham, which the Philistines had blocked after Abraham's death,
and he called them by the names his father had called them. 19 Isaac's
servants dug in the valley and struck a spring of running water,[g] 20 but
the shepherds of Gerar argued with Isaac's shepherds and said, "This
water belongs to us." So he named the well Esek,[h] because they had
disputed with him. 21 They dug a second well, and there was a dispute
about it too, so he named it Sitnah.[i] 22 He moved away from there
and dug yet another well, and nobody argued about it. He named it
Rehoboth,[j] and said, "At last Yahweh has given us space, and we shall
flourish in this land."
23 From there he went up to Beersheba. 24 That night Yahweh appeared
to him and said, "I am the God of your father Abraham. Have no fear,
for I am at your side. Because of my servant Abraham I will bless you
and make your descendants many." 25 Isaac built an altar in that place
and called upon the name of Yahweh. He set up his tent there, and
his servants began digging a well.
26 Then Abimelech came to him from Gerar, together with Ahuzzath
his counselor[k] and Phicol, the general of his army. 27 Isaac asked them,
"Why have you come to me? You hated me and drove me away from
you." 28 They answered, "We can see plainly that Yahweh is with you.
So we thought there should be a sworn agreement between us and
you. Let us make a covenant with you 29 that you will do us no wrong,

since we did not lay a hand on you, and we treated you only well, and let you go in peace. Now Yahweh has blessed you." 30 Isaac prepared a feast for them, and they ate and drank. 31 Early the next morning they swore oaths to each other. Then Isaac let them go, and they left him in peace. 32 On that same day Isaac's servants came with news of the well they had been digging. "We have struck water,"[l] they told him. 33 He named it Shibah;[m] and so the town is called Beersheba even now. 34 When Esau was forty, he married Judith, daughter of Beeri the Hittite, and Basemath, daughter of Elon the Hittite.[n] 35 These women brought grief[o] to Isaac and Rebekah.

Notes

- a (26:1) On the Philistines in the time of the patriarchs, see the note on 21:32. This Abimelech may be a successor of the king in chapter 20, since the name may be a royal title (see the note on 20:2).
- b (26:4) Or "will bless themselves," as in 22:18.
- c (26:5) Four words for God's instruction, the last being torah, "law" or "teaching." The verse describes Abraham as faithful long before the Law of Moses was given.
- d (26:8) Hebrew metsacheq, from the same root as Isaac's name ("he laughs"), here meaning the affectionate play of husband and wife. Brenton's Septuagint reads "sporting with Rebecca his wife."
- e (26:12) Literally "found a hundred measures." Brenton's Septuagint reads "found in that year barley an hundred-fold," which reflects the Hebrew word for "measures" (she'arim) read with different vowels as "barley" (se'orim).
- f (26:17) Hebrew nachal, a stream valley that may be dry except in the rainy season (a wadi).
- g (26:19) Literally "living water," that is, water flowing from a spring.
- h (26:20) Esek means "contention" or "dispute." Brenton's Septuagint translates the name "Injury."
- i (26:21) Sitnah means "hostility" or "accusation," from the same root as satan, "adversary." Brenton's Septuagint translates it "Enmity."
- j (26:22) Rehoboth means "wide places" or "room." Brenton's Septuagint translates it "Room."
- k (26:26) Literally "his friend," probably a title for a royal counselor. Brenton notes a sense like "he that gives away in marriage," that is, the king's groomsman.
- l (26:32) Brenton's Septuagint reads "We have not found water." The Hebrew lo, "to him," sounds the same as lo, "not," and was evidently read that way.
- m (26:33) Shibah means "oath" or "seven" (compare 21:31). Brenton's Septuagint translates it "Oath" and the city "the Well of Oath."
- n (26:34) Brenton notes that Codex Alexandrinus reads "Hivite" here. The lists of Esau's wives in 28:9 and 36:2–3 give partly different names.

- o (26:35) Literally “they were bitterness of spirit to Isaac and to Rebekah.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “they were provoking to Isaac and Rebecca.”

Chapter 27

1 Isaac was old, and his eyes had grown dim so that he could not see.
He summoned Esau, the elder of his two sons. “My son,” he said. And
Esau answered, “I am here.” 2 Isaac said, “I am an old man now, and I
cannot tell when I will die. 3 So take your hunting gear,[a] your quiver
and bow, go out into the countryside, and bring down some game for
me. 4 Then cook me a savory dish of the kind I like and bring it for
me to eat, so that I may give you my own blessing[b] before my death.”
5 Rebekah was listening as Isaac talked with his son Esau. So when
Esau had gone off into the countryside to hunt game and bring it
home, 6 Rebekah spoke to her son Jacob: “Now I heard your father
speak to Esau your brother, and he said, 7 ‘Bring me some game and
cook me a savory dish to eat, and I will bless you in the presence of
Yahweh before I die.’ 8 So now, my son, do exactly what I tell you. 9 Go
out to the flock and fetch me two fine young goats, and I will make
them into a savory dish for your father, just as he likes it. 10 Then take
it in to your father for him to eat, so that he will bless you before his
death.” 11 Jacob answered his mother Rebekah, “But my brother Esau
is a hairy man, and my skin is smooth. 12 What if my father touches
me? I will look like a trickster[c] to him, and I will bring a curse upon
myself instead of a blessing.” 13 His mother said to him, “Your curse
be upon me, my son; only obey my voice, and go, fetch them for me.”
14 So he went and fetched them and brought them to his mother, and
she cooked a savory dish the way his father liked it. 15 Then Rebekah
took the finest garments of Esau, her elder son, which she kept at
home, and dressed Jacob, her younger son, in them. 16 She covered his
hands and the smooth skin of his neck with the goatskins, 17 and she
handed her son Jacob the savory dish and the bread she had baked.
18 Jacob went in to his father and said, “Father.” And he answered, “I
am here. Which of my sons are you?” 19 Jacob told his father, “I am
Esau, your firstborn. I have done what you asked of me. Rise, please;
sit and eat from what I hunted, and then bless me.” 20 Isaac asked his

son, “How did you find it so fast, my son?” He answered, “Yahweh your God sent it my way.” 21 Then Isaac said to Jacob, “Come close, my son, and let me touch you, to learn whether you truly are my son Esau.” 22 Jacob stepped up to Isaac his father. Isaac felt him and said, “The voice is Jacob’s voice, but the hands are Esau’s hands.” 23 He did not know him, for his hands were hairy like his brother Esau’s hands; and so he blessed him.[d] 24 “Are you truly my son Esau?” he asked. And Jacob said, “I am.” 25 Isaac said, “Serve it to me, and let me eat my son’s game, so that I may give you my blessing.” Jacob served it to him and he ate, and he brought him wine and he drank. 26 Then his father Isaac told him, “Come here, my son, and kiss me.” 27 Jacob drew near and kissed him. Isaac smelled the fragrance of his clothing, and he blessed him, saying, “Ah, the scent of my son is like the scent of a field Yahweh has blessed.[e] 28 May God grant you dew from the sky and the fat of the land, with grain and new wine[f] in plenty. 29 May peoples be your servants and nations bow low to you. Rule over your brothers; may your mother’s sons bow low to you. A curse on all who curse you, and a blessing on all who bless you!”

30 No sooner had Isaac ended the blessing, and Jacob barely stepped out from before his father, than Esau his brother came in from hunting. 31 He also cooked a savory dish and brought it in to his father. He said to him, “Sit up, Father, and eat some of your son’s game, so that you may give me your blessing.” 32 His father Isaac asked him, “Who are you?” He answered, “I am Esau, your son, your firstborn.” 33 Isaac was seized with violent trembling[g] and said, “Then who was it that hunted game and brought it to me? I ate it all before you arrived, and I blessed him. And blessed he shall remain!” 34 When Esau heard the words of his father, he cried out, a great and exceedingly bitter cry, and said to his father, “Bless me, me also, my father!” 35 But Isaac said, “Your brother came here by trickery and has carried off your blessing.” 36 Esau said, “Is he not rightly named Jacob?[h] He has cheated me these two times: he took my birthright, and now look, he has taken my blessing.”[i] Then he asked, “Have you not reserved a blessing for me?” 37 Isaac answered Esau, “I have made him your master. I have given him all his relatives as servants, and I have supported him with

grain and new wine. So what is there for me to do for you, my son?” 38
Esau said to his father, “Do you have just one blessing, Father? Bless
me as well, Father, bless me too!” And Esau wept aloud.[j] 39 Then his
father Isaac answered him: “Far from the fat of the land shall your
home be, and far from the dew of the sky above.[k] 40 You shall live by
the sword and serve your brother; but when you break free,[l] you shall
shake his yoke off your neck.”
41 From then on Esau hated Jacob because of the blessing his father
had given him, and he said to himself, “The time of mourning for my
father is not far off; after that I will kill my brother Jacob.” 42 Someone
told Rebekah what her elder son Esau had said. So she sent for
Jacob, her younger son, and told him, “Your brother Esau is consoling
himself with the thought of killing you. 43 So, my son, do what I tell
you. Leave at once and run to my brother Laban in Haran. 44 Live
with him for a time, until your brother’s rage cools, 45 until his anger
against you passes and he forgets what you did to him. Then I will
send word and bring you back. Why should I be robbed of you both
on a single day?”[m] 46 Then Rebekah said to Isaac, “I am weary of my
life because of the daughters of Heth.[n] If Jacob takes a wife from the
daughters of Heth, like these, from the daughters of the land, my life
will not be worth living.”

Notes

- a (27:3) Hebrew keli, “equipment” or “weapons.” The word for “quiver” (teli) is found only here in the Bible; its meaning rests on ancient tradition.
- b (27:4) “My soul” (nephesh) means “I myself,” with the sense of a full and deliberate blessing. In the ancient world a dying father’s blessing was held to be binding.
- c (27:12) Or “a deceiver,” or “one who makes a fool of him.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “as one ill-intentioned.”
- d (27:23) This line may summarize the outcome before the blessing itself is given in 27:27–29.
- e (27:27) Brenton’s Septuagint reads “the smell of an abundant field.”
- f (27:28) Hebrew tirosh, freshly pressed wine. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “abundance of corn and wine,” using “corn” in the older British sense of grain.
- g (27:33) Literally “trembled a great trembling, to excess.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “was amazed with very great amazement.”
- h (27:36) Jacob (Ya’aqov) sounds like the verb aqav, “to grab by the heel,” “to overreach,” or “to supplant.” Compare 25:26 and Jeremiah 9:4.

- i (27:36) A wordplay in Hebrew: bekhorah, “birthright,” and berakhah, “blessing.”
- j (27:38) Brenton’s Septuagint adds “And Isaac being troubled” before Esau weeps; Brenton notes that these words are not in the Hebrew.
- k (27:39) Or “Look, of the richness of the earth will be your dwelling, and of the dew of heaven above.” The Hebrew preposition min can mean “away from” or “a share of.” The words echo 27:28, but the sense is probably the reverse: Edom’s land would be dry. Brenton’s Septuagint takes the second sense: “of the fatness of the earth.”
- l (27:40) The Hebrew verb (rud) is uncertain; it may mean “roam free,” “grow restless,” or “break loose.” Compare 2 Kings 8:20–22, where Edom revolts from Judah. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “there shall be a time when thou shalt break and loosen his yoke.”
- m (27:45) That is, Jacob killed by Esau, and Esau then condemned for murder (9:6) or driven away as a fugitive.
- n (27:46) The sons of Heth were a local Canaanite people (10:15; 23:3). Esau’s Hittite wives are named in 26:34–35.

Chapter 28

1 Then Isaac called Jacob, blessed him, and commanded him, “You
must not take a wife from the Canaanite women. 2 Get up, go to
Paddan-aram, to the house of Bethuel your mother’s father, and take
a wife from there, from the daughters of Laban your mother’s brother.
3 May El Shaddai[a] bless you and give you many children and increase
your number, until you grow into a gathering of peoples.[b] 4 May he
give the blessing of Abraham to you and to your offspring with you,
so that you may possess the land where you are living as a foreigner,
which God gave to Abraham.” 5 So Isaac sent Jacob away, and he went
to Paddan-aram, to Laban son of Bethuel the Aramean, the brother
of Rebekah, mother of Jacob and Esau.
6 Esau saw that Isaac had blessed Jacob and dispatched him to Paddan-
aram to take himself a wife from there, and that in blessing him
he had charged him, “You shall not take a wife from the daughters
of Canaan,” 7 and that Jacob had heeded his father and mother and
had set out for Paddan-aram. 8 Esau understood that his father Isaac
took no pleasure in the daughters of Canaan. 9 Esau went to Ishmael
and took as his wife, in addition to the wives he had, Mahalath[c] the
daughter of Ishmael, Abraham’s son, the sister of Nebaioth.

10 Jacob left Beersheba and went toward Haran. 11 He reached a certain
placed and spent the night there, for the sun had gone down. Taking
one of the stones of that place, he put it under his head and lay down
there to sleep. 12 He dreamed, and there was a stairwaye resting on
the earth, with its top touching heaven; and the angels of God were
ascending and descending on it.f 13 And there was Yahweh, standing
above it,g and he said, "I am Yahweh, the God of Abraham your father,
and the God of Isaac. To you and to your offspring I will give the land
on which you are lying. 14 Your offspring will be as the dust of the
earth, and you will spread abroad to the west, to the east, to the north,
and to the south; and in you and in your offspring all the families of
the earth will be blessed.h 15 Look, I am with you and will keep you
wherever you go, and will bring you back to this land. For I will not
leave you until I have done what I have promised you."
16 Jacob awoke out of his sleep and said, "Yahweh is truly here, in this
very place, and I was not aware of it!" 17 He was afraid and said, "How
awesome is this place! This is none other than the house of God, and
this is the gate of heaven." 18 Jacob rose early in the morning, took the
stone that he had put under his head, set it up as a standing stone,i
and poured oil on top of it. 19 He called the name of that place Bethel,j
but the name of the city was Luz at first.k 20 Then Jacob made a vow,
saying, "If God will be with me and keep me on this road that I am
traveling, and give me bread to eat and clothing to wear, 21 so that I
come back in peace to my father's house, then Yahweh will be my
God,l 22 and this stone that I have set up as a standing stone shall be a
house of God; and of everything you give me, I will surely give you
a tenth."

Notes

- a (28:3) Traditionally "God Almighty"; see the note on El Shaddai at 17:1. Brenton's Septuagint reads "my God."
- b (28:3) Hebrew qehal ammim. Qahal, "assembly," is later used of Israel gathered for worship. Brenton's Septuagint reads "gatherings of nations."
- c (28:9) Called Basemath in 36:3. Brenton's Septuagint spells the name "Maeleth."
- d (28:11) Literally "the place," perhaps implying a known holy site. The word returns again and again in this story.

- e (28:12) Hebrew sullam, found only here. It may mean a ladder, or a ramp or stairway like those on ancient temple towers (compare 11:4). Brenton's Septuagint reads "ladder."
- f (28:12) Or "on him," that is, on Jacob; the Hebrew can mean either. Jesus alludes to this verse in John 1:51.
- g (28:13) Or "standing beside him." Brenton's Septuagint reads "the Lord stood upon it."
- h (28:14) Or "will bless themselves." See the note on 12:3. Brenton's Septuagint reads "all the tribes of the earth."
- i (28:18) Hebrew matsevah, a standing stone set up as a memorial or to mark a holy place. Later law forbade such pillars when they were tied to the worship of other gods (Deuteronomy 16:22).
- j (28:19) Bethel means "house of God." Brenton's Septuagint translates the name: "the House of God."
- k (28:19) Brenton's Septuagint joins the Hebrew words for "but Luz" (ulam luz) into one name: "the name of the city before was Ulam-luz."
- l (28:21) Or "and if Yahweh will be my God, then this stone…" The Hebrew can be divided so that the vow's condition runs through this clause.

Chapter 29

1 Then Jacob went on his journey[a] and came to the land of the people
of the east. 2 As he looked, he saw a well out in the open country, and
three flocks of sheep were resting near it, because the flocks drank
from that well. A great stone covered its opening. 3 The shepherds
would wait until every flock had come together there. Then they
rolled the stone off the opening, watered the sheep, and set the stone
back over the well. 4 Jacob said to them, "My brothers, where are you
from?" They said, "We are from Haran." 5 He said to them, "Do you
know Laban the son of Nahor?"[b] They said, "We know him." 6 He said
to them, "Is it well with him?"[c] They said, "It is well. And look, here
comes Rachel his daughter with the sheep." 7 He said, "The sun is still
high, and it is too early to bring the animals in. Give the sheep water,
then take them back out to graze." 8 They said, "We are not able until
all the flocks have been gathered together and the stone has been
rolled off the mouth of the well; then we water the sheep." 9 While he
was still speaking with them, Rachel came with her father's sheep, for
she was a shepherdess. 10 When Jacob saw Rachel, daughter of Laban
his mother's brother, with the flock of Laban his mother's brother,

he stepped forward and rolled the stone from the well's opening, and he watered the sheep of Laban, brother of his mother. 11 Then Jacob kissed Rachel and lifted up his voice and wept. 12 Jacob told Rachel that he was her father's relative,[d] and that he was Rebekah's son, and she ran and told her father. 13 When Laban heard that Jacob, his sister's son, had come, he hurried out to him, threw his arms around him, kissed him, and took him home. Jacob told Laban everything that had happened, 14 and Laban said to him, "Surely you are my bone and my flesh!" And he stayed with him a month.[e]

15 Laban said to Jacob, "Is it because you are my kinsman that you must serve me for nothing? Tell me, what shall your wages be?" 16 Now Laban had two daughters. The name of the older was Leah, and the name of the younger was Rachel. 17 Leah's eyes were tender,[f] but Rachel was beautiful in form and beautiful to look at.[g] 18 Jacob loved Rachel, and he said, "I will serve you seven years for Rachel your younger daughter." 19 Laban said, "It is better that I give her to you than give her to another man. Stay with me." 20 So Jacob served seven years for Rachel, and they seemed to him but a few days because of his love for her. 21 Then Jacob said to Laban, "Give me my wife, for my time is completed, so that I may go in to her." 22 So Laban gathered all the people of the place and made a feast. 23 In the evening he took his daughter Leah and brought her to Jacob, and Jacob went in to her.[h] 24 Laban gave Zilpah, his slave woman, to his daughter Leah to be her slave woman. 25 When morning came, behold, it was Leah! So Jacob said to Laban, "What is this that you did to me? Was it not for Rachel that I served you? Why have you deceived me?"[i] 26 Laban said, "It is not done in our place to give the younger before the firstborn. 27 Finish this one's bridal week,[j] and then we will give you the younger one as well, for another seven years of work for me." 28 Jacob agreed. He finished out Leah's week, and Laban gave him his daughter Rachel to be his wife. 29 Laban gave Bilhah, his slave woman, to his daughter Rachel to be her slave woman. 30 Jacob lay with Rachel too, and he loved her more than Leah. He stayed and worked for Laban another seven years.

31 When Yahweh saw that Leah was unloved,[k] he opened her womb,
but Rachel was barren. 32 Leah conceived and bore a son, and she
called his name Reuben,[l] for she said, "Because Yahweh has looked on
my affliction; surely now my husband will love me." 33 She conceived
again and bore a son, and said, "Because Yahweh has heard that I
am unloved, he has given me this son also." And she called his name
Simeon.[m] 34 Again she conceived and bore a son, and said, "Now this
time my husband will be joined to me, because I have borne him three
sons." Therefore his name was called Levi.[n] 35 And she conceived again
and bore a son, and said, "This time I will praise Yahweh." Therefore
she called his name Judah.[o] Then she stopped bearing.

Notes

- a (29:1) Literally "Jacob lifted up his feet." Brenton gives the Greek in his note as "having lifted up his feet, went."
- b (29:5) "Son" here means descendant; Laban was Nahor's grandson (24:29).
- c (29:6) Literally "Is there peace (shalom) to him?"
- d (29:12) Literally "brother." Jacob was Laban's nephew.
- e (29:14) Literally "a month of days." Brenton's note gives the Greek the same way; his text reads "a full month."
- f (29:17) Hebrew rakkot, "tender," "soft," or "weak." It may be praise (gentle eyes) or a contrast with Rachel's beauty. Brenton's Septuagint reads "weak." The names Leah and Rachel may mean "wild cow" and "ewe."
- g (29:17) Literally "beautiful of form and beautiful of appearance."
- h (29:23) The bride was probably veiled (compare 24:65), and the evening dark.
- i (29:25) Hebrew rimmitani, from the same root as the "deceit" (mirmah) by which Jacob took Esau's blessing (27:35). The deceiver is deceived.
- j (29:27) The wedding feast lasted seven days (compare Judges 14:12).
- k (29:31) Literally "hated," a Hebrew way of saying "loved less" (compare 29:30; Deuteronomy 21:15; Malachi 1:2–3). Brenton's Septuagint reads "hated."
- l (29:32) Reuben sounds like re'u ben, "See, a son!" and like Leah's words ra'ah be'onyi, "he has looked on my affliction."
- m (29:33) Simeon sounds like shama, "he has heard."
- n (29:34) Levi sounds like yillaweh, "he will be joined."
- o (29:35) Judah sounds like odeh, "I will praise."

Chapter 30

1 When Rachel saw that she bore Jacob no children, Rachel envied
her sister. She said to Jacob, "Give me children, or else I am dead!"[a] 2
Jacob's anger burned against Rachel, and he said, "Am I in the place of

God, who has kept from you the fruit of the womb?" 3 She said, "Here is Bilhah, my servant. Sleep with her, and let her bear children upon my knees,[b] so that through her I too may be built up with children.[c]" 4 So she gave him Bilhah her slave woman as a wife, and Jacob went in to her. 5 Bilhah conceived and bore Jacob a son. 6 Then Rachel said, "God has judged me, and he has also heard my voice and given me a son." Therefore she called his name Dan.[d] 7 Bilhah, Rachel's slave woman, conceived again and bore Jacob a second son. 8 Rachel said, "I have struggled with mighty wrestlings[e] against my sister, and I have prevailed." So she named him Naphtali. 9 When Leah saw that she had stopped bearing, she took Zilpah her slave woman and gave her to Jacob as a wife. 10 Then Zilpah, Leah's slave woman, bore Jacob a son. 11 Leah said, "Fortune has come!"[f] and she named him Gad. 12 Zilpah, Leah's slave woman, bore Jacob a second son. 13 Leah said, "What joy is mine! The women will count me blessed." And she named him Asher.[g]

14 In the days of wheat harvest Reuben went out and found mandrakes[h] in the field and brought them to Leah his mother. Then Rachel said to Leah, "Please give me some of your son's mandrakes." 15 Leah answered her, "Was it not enough that you took my husband? Now will you take my son's mandrakes as well?" Rachel replied, "Very well, he will sleep with you tonight, and your son's mandrakes will be the price." 16 When Jacob came in from the field in the evening, Leah went out to meet him and said, "You must come in to me, for I have hired you with my son's mandrakes." So he lay with her that night. 17 God listened to Leah, and she conceived and bore Jacob a fifth son. 18 Leah said, "God has given me my wages, because I gave my slave woman to my husband." So she called his name Issachar.[i] 19 Leah conceived again and bore Jacob a sixth son. 20 Leah said, "God has given me a fine dowry. This time my husband will hold me in honor,[j] since I have given him six sons." And she named him Zebulun. 21 Afterward she bore a daughter and called her name Dinah.[k] 22 Then God remembered Rachel. God listened to her and opened her womb. 23 She conceived and bore a son and said, "God has taken away my

disgrace." 24 And she called his name Joseph,[l] saying, "May Yahweh
add to me another son!"
25 After Rachel had borne Joseph, Jacob said to Laban, "Send me away,
so that I may go to my own place and my own country. 26 Give me my
wives and my children, for whom I have served you, and let me go,
for you know the service I have given you." 27 But Laban answered,
"If you look on me with kindness, stay. I have seen by the signs[m]
that Yahweh has blessed me for your sake." 28 He said, "Name your
wages, and I will give it." 29 He answered, "You yourself know how I
served you and how your livestock fared under my care. 30 The little
you had before I came has grown into a multitude, and Yahweh has
blessed you wherever I set foot.[n] But now, when shall I do something
for my own house as well?" 31 He said, "What shall I give you?" Jacob
said, "You shall not give me anything. If you will do this one thing
for me, I will again pasture your flock and keep it. 32 Today I will
go through all your flocks and take out of them each sheep that is
speckled or spotted, each dark lamb, and each goat that is spotted or
speckled. Those will be my pay.[o] 33 In time to come my honesty will
speak for me. Whenever you come to check my pay, any goat among
mine that is not speckled or spotted, and any lamb that is not dark,
you may count as stolen." 34 "Agreed," said Laban. "It will be just as
you say." 35 That same day Laban set apart the male goats that were
streaked and spotted, and all the female goats that were speckled and
spotted, every one with white in it, and every dark one among the
lambs, and he placed them in the care of his sons. 36 He set three days'
travel between himself and Jacob; and Jacob went on shepherding
what remained of Laban's flocks. 37 Jacob cut green branches of poplar,
almond, and plane tree,[p] and stripped the bark in white stripes, laying
bare the white wood beneath. 38 Then he placed the stripped branches
in the drinking troughs, facing the flocks, at the places where the
flocks came for water. The animals bred when they came to drink, 39
the flocks mated in front of the rods, and the flocks bore young that
were striped, speckled, and spotted.[q] 40 Jacob separated the lambs, and
set the faces of the flocks toward the striped and all the dark in the
flock of Laban. He put his own flocks apart and did not put them

with Laban's flock. 41 Whenever the stronger of the flock were mating,
Jacob would lay the rods in the troughs before the eyes of the flock,
so that they would mate among the rods, 42 but for the feebler of the
flock he would not put them there. So the feebler were Laban's, and
the stronger Jacob's.[r] 43 Thus the man grew exceedingly rich, and had
large flocks, female and male servants, camels, and donkeys.

Notes

- a (30:1) Literally "if not, I am dying." Rachel later dies giving birth to her second son (35:16–19).
- b (30:3) A rite of adoption or of claiming the child as one's own (compare 48:12; 50:23).
- c (30:3) Literally "I will be built," a play on ben, "son." See the note on 16:2.
- d (30:6) Dan sounds like dan, "he has judged" or "vindicated." Brenton's Septuagint reads "God has given judgment for me."
- e (30:8) Literally "wrestlings of God," a Hebrew way of saying "mighty wrestlings" (compare the note on 23:6). Naphtali sounds like niphtalti, "I have wrestled." Brenton's Septuagint reads "God has helped me, and I contended with my sister and prevailed."
- f (30:11) The written Hebrew reads begad, "with good fortune"; the Masoretic reading tradition divides it as ba gad, "good fortune has come." Gad was also the name of a god of fortune (Isaiah 65:11). Brenton's Septuagint reads "It is happily."
- g (30:13) Asher sounds like ashrei, "happy" or "blessed." Brenton's Septuagint reads "I am blessed, for the women will pronounce me blessed."
- h (30:14) Hebrew duda'im, a plant whose root and fruit were believed to help conception; the name sounds like dodim, "love." Brenton's Septuagint reads "apples of mandrakes" and dates this to "the day of barley-harvest."
- i (30:18) Issachar sounds like sakhar, "wages" or "hire" (30:16). Brenton's Septuagint explains the name: "Issachar, which is, Reward."
- j (30:20) Or "will dwell with me." Zebulun sounds like both zebed, "gift," and zabal, a rare verb meaning "honor" or "dwell." Brenton's Septuagint reads "my husband will choose me."
- k (30:21) Dinah's name, from the same root as Dan, is not explained. Her story is told in chapter 34.
- l (30:24) Joseph sounds like both asaph, "he has taken away" (30:23), and yoseph, "may he add."
- m (30:27) Or "I have grown rich." Hebrew nichashti usually means "I have practiced divination" (compare 44:5). Brenton's Septuagint reads "I would augur well."
- n (30:30) Literally "at my foot." Brenton notes that both the Greek and the Hebrew literally read "at my foot."

- o (30:32) In that region sheep were usually white and goats dark, so the speckled, spotted, and dark animals would have been few. Brenton's Septuagint has Jacob take "every grey sheep among the rams" together with the speckled and spotted goats.
- p (30:37) The trees cannot be identified with certainty. Hebrew livneh, "poplar," sounds like lavan, "white," and like Laban's name; the wordplay runs through the passage. Brenton's Septuagint reads "storax tree and walnut and plane-tree."
- q (30:39) Ancient herders believed that what a mother saw at mating could mark her young. Jacob later credits the result to God, not to his own method (31:9–12).
- r (30:42) The meaning of "stronger" and "feebler" is uncertain; they may refer to sturdy and weak animals or to animals breeding at different seasons. Brenton notes that the Septuagint, by making the birthing time the reason, has "obscured the passage."

Chapter 31

1 Word reached Jacob that Laban's sons were complaining, "Jacob has
seized everything our father owned. Out of our father's goods he
has built up all these riches."[a] 2 And Jacob saw that Laban's face was
not toward him as it had been before.[b] 3 Then Yahweh said to Jacob,
"Return to the land of your fathers and to your relatives, and I will be
with you." 4 Jacob sent for Rachel and Leah and had them come out to
the open country where his flocks were. 5 and said to them, "I see that
your father's face is not toward me as it was before. But the God of
my father has been with me. 6 You know that I have served your father
with all my strength. 7 Yet your father has cheated me and changed my
wages ten times.[c] But God did not let him harm me. 8 If he said, 'The
speckled will be your wages,' then all the flock bore speckled young.
And if he said, 'The striped will be your wages,' then all the flock
bore striped young. 9 So God has taken away your father's livestock
and given them to me. 10 At the time the flocks were breeding, I had
a dream. I looked up and saw that the he-goats leaping on the flock
were striped, speckled, and mottled. 11 Then the angel of God said to
me in the dream, 'Jacob.' And I said, 'Here I am.' 12 He said, 'Look up
and see: all the male goats that mount the flock are streaked, speckled,
and spotted, for I have seen everything Laban is doing to you. 13 I am
the God of Bethel,[d] where you anointed a standing stone, where you
made a vow to me. Now rise, go out from this land, and return to

the land of your birth.'" 14 Rachel and Leah replied, "Do we have any
share left, or anything to inherit, from our father's household? 15 Are
we not regarded by him as foreigners? For he has sold us, and he has
completely used up the money paid for us.[e] 16 All the riches God has
stripped from our father are ours and our children's. So go ahead and
do everything God has said to you."
17 So Jacob got up and set his sons and his wives on camels. 18 He drove
away all his livestock and all the goods he had gained, the livestock
he had acquired in Paddan-aram, to go to Isaac his father in the land
of Canaan. 19 Laban had gone to shear his sheep, and Rachel stole
her father's household gods.[f] 20 Jacob also stole the heart of Laban the
Aramean[g] by keeping from him the news that he was running away.
21 He fled with all that he had. He rose, crossed the River,[h] and turned
his face toward the hill country of Gilead.
22 Two days later, on the third day, someone told Laban that Jacob had
run away. 23 Taking his kinsmen with him, he chased after Jacob for
a seven days' journey and overtook him in the hills of Gilead. 24 But
God came to Laban the Aramean in a dream by night and said to him,
"Be careful that you say nothing to Jacob, either good or bad."[i]
25 Laban overtook Jacob, who had his tent pitched on the mountain;
and Laban and his kinsmen camped in the hill country of Gilead. 26
And Laban said to Jacob, "What have you done? You have deceived
me and carried off my daughters like captives of the sword! 27 Why did
you run away in secret and cheat me? You did not tell me, or I would
have sent you off with joy and with songs, with tambourine and with
lyre. 28 You did not even let me kiss my grandsons and my daughters
goodbye. Now you have acted foolishly. 29 It is in my power to do you
harm. But the God of your father spoke to me last night, saying, 'Be
careful that you say nothing to Jacob, either good or bad.' 30 Now you
have left because you were homesick for your father's house. Even
so, why have you taken my gods?" 31 Jacob replied to Laban, "I was
afraid. I told myself that you might seize your daughters from me. 32
As for your gods, whoever is found to have them will not stay alive.
With our kinsmen watching, search for anything of yours that I have,
and take it back." Jacob had no idea that Rachel had taken them. 33

Laban searched Jacob's tent, then Leah's tent, then the tent of the two servant women, and found nothing. After he came out of Leah's tent, he went into Rachel's. 34 Now Rachel had taken the household gods and put them in the camel's saddle and sat on them. Laban felt all through the tent but did not find them. 35 Rachel said to her father, "My lord, do not be angry that I do not stand up in your presence. It is the time of month for me."[j] He searched everywhere, but the household gods did not turn up. 36 Jacob was angry and found fault with Laban, and in reply Jacob said to Laban, "What is my crime? What is my sin, that you have hotly pursued me? 37 You have searched through all my belongings; what have you found of all your household possessions? Put it here before my kinsmen and your kinsmen, and let them judge between the two of us. 38 I have spent twenty years with you now. Your ewes and your female goats never miscarried, and I never ate the rams of your flock. 39 When an animal was mauled by beasts, I never brought it back to you; I made good the loss myself. You demanded payment from me for anything stolen, whether it was taken in the daytime or in the night. 40 That was my life: the heat wore me down by day and the frost by night, and sleep would not come to my eyes. 41 These twenty years I have been in your house. I served you fourteen years for your two daughters, and six years for your flock, and you have changed my wages ten times. 42 Had the God of my father, the God of Abraham and the Fear of Isaac,[k] not stood with me, you would have sent me off now with nothing in my hands. But God took note of how I was wronged and how hard I worked, and last night he gave his judgment."

43 Laban answered Jacob, "These women are my daughters, these children are my grandchildren, these flocks are my flocks. Everything in front of you belongs to me. Yet what can I do now for my daughters here, or for the children they have had? 44 So come, you and I will cut a covenant, and it will stand as a witness between us."[l] 45 So Jacob took a stone and set it up as a standing stone. 46 And Jacob said to his relatives, "Gather stones." They took stones and made a heap, and they ate there by the heap. 47 Laban called it Jegar-sahadutha, but Jacob called it Galeed.[m] 48 Laban said, "This heap is a witness between me and you

today." That is why it was named Galeed, [49] and also Mizpah,[n] because he said, "May Yahweh watch between me and you when we are out of each other's sight. [50] If you treat my daughters badly, or marry other wives besides them, remember that even when no one else is present with us, God is watching as witness between us." [51] Then Laban said to Jacob, "See this heap and see the standing stone, which I have set up between me and you.[o] [52] This mound bears witness, and the pillar bears witness, that I will not cross over past this mound into your land, and you will not cross over past this mound and this pillar into mine, to do harm. [53] May the God of Abraham and the God of Nahor, the God of their father, judge between us."[p] So Jacob swore by the Fear of his father Isaac. [54] Jacob offered a sacrifice there on the mountain and invited his kinsmen to share the meal. They ate together and stayed the night on the mountain. [55] Early in the morning Laban rose and kissed his grandsons and his daughters and blessed them. Then Laban departed and returned to his home.[q]

Notes

- a (31:1) Literally "all this glory" (kavod), here meaning wealth and the honor that goes with it.
- b (31:2) Literally "was not with him as yesterday and the day before," a Hebrew way of saying "as before." Brenton notes the same idiom in the Greek.
- c (31:7) "Ten times" means "again and again." Brenton's Septuagint reads "changed my wages for the ten lambs."
- d (31:13) Hebrew ha'el bet-el, "the God of Bethel." Brenton's Septuagint reads "I am God that appeared to thee in the place of God."
- e (31:15) Literally "he has eaten, yes eaten, our money," that is, the bride price that should in part have come to the daughters. Laban had been paid in fourteen years of Jacob's labor.
- f (31:19) Hebrew teraphim, small figures kept in the home, possibly images of ancestors or household protectors, and perhaps linked with inheritance or divination. Brenton's Septuagint reads "images."
- g (31:20) Literally "stole the heart of Laban," meaning he deceived him. The same verb is used of Rachel stealing the household gods (31:19). Brenton's Septuagint reads "Jacob hid the matter from Laban the Syrian."
- h (31:21) That is, the Euphrates.
- i (31:24) Literally "from good to bad," meaning that Laban must not try to persuade or threaten Jacob into returning.

- j (31:35) That is, she was having her monthly period. Later law treated anything she sat on at that time as unclean (Leviticus 15:19–23), which adds irony to Laban's gods being hidden under her.
- k (31:42) Hebrew pachad yitschaq, "the Fear of Isaac," that is, the God whom Isaac feared, or possibly "the Kinsman of Isaac." The title appears again in 31:53. Brenton's Septuagint reads "the fear of Isaac."
- l (31:44) The Hebrew says "let it be a witness" without naming what "it" is; the covenant is probably meant.
- m (31:47) Both names mean "heap of witness," Laban's in Aramaic and Jacob's in Hebrew. The Aramaic words are the first in the Bible. Galeed sounds like Gilead. Brenton's Septuagint translates the names: "the Heap of Testimony" and "the Witness Heap."
- n (31:49) Mizpah means "watchtower" or "lookout," from tsaphah, "to watch." Brenton's Septuagint reads "the vision."
- o (31:51) Brenton's Septuagint arranges 31:48–52 differently and numbers one part as an extra verse.
- p (31:53) The verb "judge" is plural in Hebrew, which may suggest that Laban thought of two gods. The words "the God of their father" are absent from Brenton's Septuagint.
- q (31:55) In the Hebrew text this verse is 32:1, and the verses of chapter 32 are numbered one higher than in English. Brenton's Septuagint follows the Hebrew numbering. This translation uses the English numbering.

Chapter 32

1 Jacob went on his way, and the angels of God met him. 2 When Jacob saw them, he said, "This is God's camp!" So he called the name of that place Mahanaim.[a]

3 Jacob sent envoys ahead of himself to Esau his brother, to the land of Seir, the territory of Edom. 4 He instructed them: "You shall say this to my lord Esau: 'Your servant Jacob says: I have been staying with Laban as a resident alien, and I have remained until now. 5 I have oxen, donkeys, and flocks, and male servants and female servants. I am sending this message to my lord, hoping to find favor in your sight.'" 6 The messengers returned to Jacob with this report: "We came to your brother Esau; he is already on his way to meet you, and four hundred men are with him." 7 Then Jacob was greatly afraid and distressed. He divided the people who were with him, and the flocks and herds and camels, into two camps, 8 He reasoned, "Should Esau attack one group and destroy it, the other group can get away."

9 Jacob said, “God of my father Abraham, and God of my father Isaac,
Yahweh, who said to me, ‘Go back to your land and to your kindred,
and I will treat you well,’ 10 I am too small for all the steadfast love[b]
and all the faithfulness you have shown me, your servant. When I
crossed this Jordan I had nothing but my staff, and now I have grown
into two companies. 11 Please deliver me from the hand of my brother,
from the hand of Esau, for I fear him, that he may come and strike me,
the mothers with the children.[c] 12 But you said, ‘I will surely do you
good and make your offspring like the sand of the sea, which cannot
be counted for multitude.’”
13 Jacob spent the night there. Then, out of what he owned, he chose a
present for his brother Esau: 14 two hundred female goats and twenty
male goats, two hundred ewes and twenty rams, 15 thirty milking
camels and their young, forty cows and ten bulls, twenty female don-
keys and ten male donkeys. 16 He handed them over to his servants,
each drove separately, and told his servants, “Cross over before me,
and put a space between drove and drove.” 17 He gave orders to the
man leading the first drove: “When my brother Esau comes upon you
and asks, ‘Whose man are you? Where are you headed? Who owns
these animals in front of you?’ 18 then answer, ‘They are your servant
Jacob’s. He is sending them as a present for my lord Esau, and he
himself is following after us.’” 19 He commanded the second and the
third and all who followed the herds in the same way: “You shall say
the same thing to Esau when you find him, 20 and you shall also say,
‘Your servant Jacob is behind us.’” For he thought, “I will appease him[d]
with the present going before me, and after that I will see his face;
perhaps he will accept me.”[e] 21 So the gift went on ahead of him, and
he himself stayed that night in the camp.
22 During that night he rose, took his two wives and his two slave
women, along with his eleven children, and crossed the Jabbok at the
ford.[f] 23 He sent them over the stream, together with all his posses-
sions. 24 And Jacob was left alone. And a man wrestled[g] with him until
the break of dawn. 25 The man saw that he could not overpower Jacob,
so he struck the hollow of Jacob’s hip, and the hip was wrenched as
the two wrestled. 26 Then he said, “Let me go, for the dawn has broken.”

But Jacob said, “I will not let you go unless you bless me.” 27 He said
to him, “What is your name?” And he said, “Jacob.” 28 He said, “Your
name shall not be called Jacob any longer, but Israel,[h] because you
have contended with God and with men, and you have prevailed.” 29
Jacob asked, “Please tell me your name.” He replied, “Why do you ask
about my name?” Then he blessed him there. 30 Jacob named the place
Peniel,[i] “because,” he said, “I saw God face to face, and still I am alive.”
31 The sun was coming up over him as he went on past Penuel,[j] and
he limped on account of his hip. 32 For this reason the Israelites, even
now, do not eat the thigh sinew[k] over the hip joint, because Jacob was
struck at the hip joint, on that sinew.

Notes

- a (32:2) Mahanaim means “two camps.” The word returns in 32:7 and 32:10, where Jacob divides his people into two camps. Brenton’s Septuagint translates it “Encampments.” In the Hebrew text this verse is 32:3; see the note on 31:55.
- b (32:10) Hebrew chesed, God’s loyal, covenant love. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “Let there be to me a sufficiency of all the justice and all the truth,” taking the opening words differently.
- c (32:11) Literally “the mother upon the children,” a proverb for total slaughter (compare Hosea 10:14).
- d (32:20) Literally “I will cover his face,” an expression for making amends. The word “face” runs through 32:20–31 and 33:10, leading up to Peniel, “face of God.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “I will propitiate his countenance.”
- e (32:20) Literally “perhaps he will lift up my face.”
- f (32:22) The Jabbok (Yabboq) sounds like the verb for “wrestled” (ye’aveq) in 32:24, and like Jacob’s name.
- g (32:24) Hebrew ye’aveq, found only here and in 32:25. Hosea 12:3–4 says that Jacob “strove with God” and “strove with the angel.”
- h (32:28) Israel probably means “God strives” or “may God rule,” but here it is explained as “he strives with God.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “for thou hast prevailed with God, and shalt be mighty with men.”
- i (32:30) Peniel means “face of God.” Brenton’s Septuagint translates it “the Face of God.”
- j (32:31) Penuel is another spelling of Peniel, used for the town in Judges 8:8 and 1 Kings 12:25.
- k (32:32) Probably the sciatic nerve. This custom is not found in the Law of Moses but was kept in later Jewish practice.

Chapter 33

1 Jacob looked up and saw Esau approaching with four hundred men.
He divided the children between Leah, Rachel, and the two servant
women. 2 He placed the servant women and their children at the front,
Leah and her children behind them, and Rachel and Joseph at the
very back. 3 He crossed over in front of them and bowed himself to
the earth seven times, until he had come close to his brother. 4 But
Esau ran to meet him and embraced him, fell on his neck and kissed
him,[a] and they wept. 5 When Esau lifted his eyes and saw the women
and the children, he asked, "Who are these that are with you?" He
said, "The children whom God has graciously given your servant." 6
Then the slave women came near, they and their children, and bowed
down. 7 Leah likewise and her children came near and bowed down.
Last of all Joseph and Rachel came near, and they bowed down. 8 Esau
asked, "What was the meaning of all those droves I came upon?"
Jacob said, "I hoped to win my lord's favor." 9 But Esau said, "I have
plenty, my brother. Keep what you have for yourself." 10 Jacob said,
"No, please. If I have found favor in your eyes, then accept my gift
from my hand. For truly I have seen your face, as one sees the face of
God, and you have received me favorably.[b] 11 Please take my blessing[c]
that has been brought to you, for God has been gracious to me, and I
have everything." He pressed him, and he accepted it.
12 Then Esau said, "Let us set out on our journey, and I will go ahead
of you." 13 Jacob replied, "My lord can see that the children are young
and weak, and I have to think of the sheep and cattle that are nursing.
If the animals are pushed hard even one day, the whole flock will
die. 14 Let my lord please pass on ahead of his servant. I will move
along at an easy pace, according to the pace of the livestock before me
and according to the pace of the children, until I come to my lord in
Seir."[d] 15 Esau said, "Let me at least leave with you some of the people
who are with me." But he said, "Why should you? Let me only find
favor in my lord's sight." 16 So Esau returned that day on his way to
Seir. 17 But Jacob journeyed to Succoth, and built himself a house and
made shelters for his livestock. Therefore the name of the place is
called Succoth.[e]

18 After his return from Paddan-aram, Jacob arrived in peace[f] at the
city of Shechem in Canaan, and he set up camp facing the city. 19 For
a hundred qesitah[g] he purchased the plot of ground where he had put
up his tent from the sons of Hamor, the father of Shechem. 20 There
he set up an altar and called it El Elohe Israel.[h]

Notes

- a (33:4) In the Hebrew text the word "and kissed him" is marked with special dots by the scribes, an old sign that the word was discussed or doubted. Some later interpreters took the dots to question Esau's sincerity.
- b (33:10) Compare 32:30. Brenton's Septuagint reads "I have seen thy face, as if any one should see the face of God."
- c (33:11) That is, the gift. The word berakhah, "blessing," recalls the blessing Jacob took from Esau (27:35–36).
- d (33:14) There is no record that Jacob went to Seir; he turned west instead (33:17).
- e (33:17) Succoth means "shelters" or "booths." Brenton's Septuagint translates it "Booths."
- f (33:18) Hebrew shalem, "whole" or "in peace," fulfilling Jacob's vow in 28:21. Brenton's Septuagint takes it as a place name: "Jacob came to Salem, a city of Secima."
- g (33:19) Hebrew qesitah, a unit of money or weight whose value is unknown, so no modern equivalent is given. Brenton's Septuagint reads "a hundred lambs." Joshua 24:32 says Joseph's bones were buried in this plot, and John 4:5 refers to it.
- h (33:20) Hebrew El Elohe Israel, "God, the God of Israel" or "God is the God of Israel." Brenton's Septuagint reads "and called on the God of Israel."

Chapter 34

1 Once Dinah, Leah's daughter by Jacob, went out to see the young
women who lived in that region. 2 Shechem son of Hamor the Hivite,[a]
the chief of that land, saw her; and he took her, lay with her, and
humiliated her.[b] 3 His heart was bound to Dinah, Jacob's daughter.
He loved the girl and spoke to her heart.[c] 4 So Shechem spoke to his
father Hamor, saying, "Get me this girl as my wife." 5 News came to
Jacob that he had defiled Dinah his daughter. His sons were out in the
open field with his herds, and Jacob kept silent until they came in. 6
And Hamor the father of Shechem went out to Jacob to speak with
him. 7 Jacob's sons came in from the field when they heard it. The
men were distressed and furiously angry, because he had committed
an outrage[d] in Israel by lying with Jacob's daughter—a thing that

must not be done. 8 But Hamor spoke with them, saying, “The soul
of my son Shechem longs for your daughter. Please give her to him
as his wife. 9 Intermarry with us. Give your daughters to us, and take
our daughters for yourselves. 10 Settle among us. The country lies
before you. Stay here, move about freely, and get land of your own.”
11 Shechem also said to her father and to her brothers, “Let me find
favor in your eyes, and whatever you say to me I will give. 12 Set the
bride price[e] and the gifts as high as you like, and I will pay whatever
you ask. Just let me have the girl for my wife.”
13 Because Shechem had defiled their sister Dinah, Jacob’s sons gave
Shechem and Hamor his father a crafty answer.[f] 14 They told them,
“We are not able to do such a thing. To give our sister to a man
without circumcision would bring shame upon us. 15 We will consent
on one condition: you must become like us, with every male of yours
circumcised. 16 After that we will give you our daughters and marry
your daughters. We will settle among you, and we will be a single
people. 17 But if you will not listen to us and be circumcised, then
we will take our daughter and go.” 18 Their words pleased Hamor and
Hamor’s son Shechem. 19 The young man lost no time in doing it, for
Jacob’s daughter was his delight. He was the most respected man in
his whole family. 20 Hamor and Shechem his son went to their city gate
and addressed the men of the city. 21 “These men are peaceable with
us; let them settle in the land and trade in it, for the land is spacious
enough for them. We will take their daughters as wives and give
them our daughters. 22 Only on this condition will the men consent
to dwell with us and become a single people: every male among us
must be circumcised, just as they are circumcised. 23 Their herds, their
goods, and every animal they own, will these not become ours? Let
us only consent to their terms, and they will settle among us.” 24 And
all who went out of the gate of his city listened to Hamor and his son
Shechem, and every male was circumcised, all who went out of the
gate of his city.[g]
25 Three days later, while the men were still sore, Simeon and Levi,
two of Jacob’s sons and full brothers of Dinah, took up their swords,
entered the unsuspecting city,[h] and put every male to death. 26 They

killed Hamor and his son Shechem with the edge of the sword, took Dinah out of Shechem's house, and went away. 27 The sons of Jacob came upon the slain and plundered the city, because they had defiled their sister. 28 They carried off sheep, cattle, and donkeys, and everything else, both inside the city and out in the fields. 29 All their wealth, all their little ones and their wives, they captured and carried off, and all that was in the houses. 30 Jacob said to Simeon and Levi, "You have ruined me. You have made my name a stench[i] among the people who live in this land, the Canaanites and the Perizzites. We are only a handful. If they band together and fall on me, I will be wiped out, my household and I." 31 They replied, "Was he to use our sister as a harlot?"[j]

Notes

- a (34:2) Brenton notes that Codex Alexandrinus reads "the Chorrhaean" (Horite). Brenton's main text reads "the Evite," that is, Hivite.
- b (34:2) Hebrew 'innah, "humbled," "violated." The verbs describe a forced act.
- c (34:3) A Hebrew idiom for speaking kindly or tenderly, as one who woos. Brenton notes that the Greek is a literal version of this Hebrew idiom.
- d (34:7) Hebrew nevalah, a word for a grave moral outrage, a deed of senseless wickedness (compare Deuteronomy 22:21; 2 Samuel 13:12). "In Israel" here may mean the family of Israel, that is, Jacob.
- e (34:12) Hebrew mohar, the payment from the groom to the bride's family (compare Exodus 22:16–17; Deuteronomy 22:29).
- f (34:13) Hebrew mirmah, the same word used of Jacob's deceit in 27:35. Brenton's Septuagint reads "craftily."
- g (34:24) Probably meaning all the men who took part in the city's public life (compare 23:10).
- h (34:25) Or "came against the city unexpectedly." Hebrew betach, "in security," may refer either to the city or to the attackers. Brenton's Septuagint reads "came upon the city securely."
- i (34:30) Literally "making me stink," that is, making me hateful. Jacob's judgment on Simeon and Levi returns in 49:5–7.
- j (34:31) The chapter ends with the brothers' question unanswered.

Chapter 35

1 God said to Jacob, "Get up, go up to Bethel and live there. Make an altar there to the God who appeared to you when you fled from your brother Esau." 2 So Jacob said to his household and to all who were

with him, “Put away the foreign gods that are among you, purify yourselves, and change your clothes. 3 Let us rise and go up to Bethel, and I will make an altar there to the God who answered me on the day of my distress and has been with me on the road I have traveled.” 4 They handed over to Jacob every foreign god they had, along with the rings from their ears.[a] Jacob buried them beneath the great tree[b] near Shechem. 5 As they set out, a dread from God[c] lay on the towns all around, and no one chased after Jacob’s sons. 6 And Jacob came to Luz (that is, Bethel), which is in the land of Canaan, he and all the people who were with him, 7 He built an altar there and called the place El Bethel,[d] because there God had revealed himself to him when he fled from his brother. 8 And Deborah, Rebekah’s nurse, died, and she was buried below Bethel under an oak. So its name was called Allon-bacuth.[e]

9 God appeared to Jacob again, when he came from Paddan-aram, and blessed him. 10 God said to him, “Your name is Jacob, but you will be called Jacob no more. Your name will be Israel.” And so he named him Israel.[f] 11 God said to him, “I am El Shaddai.[g] Be fruitful and increase. A nation, and a gathering of nations, will spring from you, and kings will descend from you.[h] 12 This land, which I gave to Abraham and to Isaac, I now give to you, and after you I will give it to your descendants.” 13 Then God went up from him in the place where he had spoken with him. 14 Jacob raised up a standing stone in the place where he had spoken with him, a standing stone of stone. He poured a drink offering upon it and poured oil upon it. 15 So Jacob called the name of the place where God had spoken with him Bethel. 16 They set out from Bethel.[i] While there was still a stretch of road[j] before Ephrath, Rachel began to give birth, and her labor was severe. 17 At the worst of her pains the midwife told her, “Take heart. This one is a son for you too.” 18 As her soul went out (for she was dying), she called his name Ben-oni,[k] but his father called him Benjamin.[l] 19 Rachel died there and was buried beside the road to Ephrath, which is Bethlehem.[m] 20 and Jacob set up a standing stone over her tomb. It is the standing stone of Rachel’s tomb, to this day. 21 Israel journeyed on and pitched his tent beyond the tower of Eder.[n]

22 While Israel lived in that land, Reuben went and lay with Bilhah
his father's concubine. And Israel heard of it.[o] Now the sons of Jacob
were twelve. 23 The sons of Leah: Reuben (Jacob's firstborn), Simeon,
Levi, Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun. 24 The sons of Rachel: Joseph and
Benjamin. 25 The sons of Bilhah, Rachel's slave woman: Dan and
Naphtali. 26 The sons of Zilpah, Leah's slave woman: Gad and Asher.
These were the sons of Jacob who were born to him in Paddan-aram.[p]
27 Jacob came home to his father Isaac at Mamre near Kiriath-arba,
which is Hebron, the place where Abraham and Isaac had stayed as
sojourners. 28 Now the days of Isaac were a hundred and eighty years.
29 And Isaac breathed his last and died, and was gathered to his people,
old and full of days. And his sons Esau and Jacob buried him.[q]

Notes

- a (35:4) Earrings could be amulets or bear the marks of other gods (compare Exodus 32:2–4; Judges 8:24–27). Brenton's Septuagint adds that Jacob hid them "and destroyed them to this day."
- b (35:4) Or "terebinth." Brenton's Septuagint reads "the turpentine tree." Compare 12:6.
- c (35:5) Or "a great terror." Literally "a terror of God," which can mean a terror sent by God or a very great terror (compare the note on 30:8).
- d (35:7) Hebrew El Bethel, "God of Bethel." Brenton's Septuagint reads simply "Bæthel," as do some other ancient witnesses.
- e (35:8) Allon-bacuth means "oak of weeping." Brenton's Septuagint translates it "The Oak of Mourning."
- f (35:10) Compare 32:28, where the name is first given.
- g (35:11) Traditionally "God Almighty"; see the note on El Shaddai at 17:1. Brenton's Septuagint reads "I am thy God."
- h (35:11) Literally "from your loins."
- i (35:16) Brenton's Septuagint places here the words of 35:21, "and pitched his tent beyond the tower of Gader," and Brenton marks them in brackets.
- j (35:16) Hebrew kivrat-ha'arets, a distance whose length is unknown (also in 48:7). Brenton's Septuagint treats it as a place name, "Chabratha."
- k (35:18) Ben-oni means "son of my sorrow" or, less likely, "son of my strength" (compare 49:3). Brenton's Septuagint reads "The son of my pain."
- l (35:18) Benjamin means "son of the right hand," that is, a son of honor or of good fortune. It can also mean "son of the south," since the right hand pointed south for one facing east.
- m (35:19) Compare 48:7. First Samuel 10:2 places Rachel's tomb in the territory of Benjamin, north of Jerusalem; the identification with Bethlehem may reflect a

later tradition. Matthew 2:18 quotes Jeremiah 31:15, where Rachel weeps for her children.

- n (35:21) Or "Migdal-eder," meaning "tower of the flock." Compare Micah 4:8.
- o (35:22) Brenton's Septuagint adds "and the thing appeared grievous before him." In the Hebrew text there is a space within the verse here, as if a paragraph ends. Compare 49:4.
- p (35:26) Benjamin, born near Ephrath (35:16–18), is included in this summary.
- q (35:29) Isaac's death is reported here to close his story, though the account of Joseph that follows begins while Isaac is still alive (compare 25:26; 37:2; 41:46; 47:9).

Chapter 36

1 These are the generations of Esau (that is, Edom). 2 Esau took his
wives from the Canaanite women: Adah the daughter of Elon the
Hittite, Oholibamah the daughter of Anah the daughter[a] of Zibeon the
Hivite, 3 and Basemath, Ishmael's daughter, the sister of Nebaioth.[b]
4 By Esau, Adah gave birth to Eliphaz, and Basemath gave birth to
Reuel. 5 Oholibamah bore Jeush, Jalam, and Korah. These are the sons
of Esau who were born to him in the land of Canaan. 6 Then Esau took
his wives, his sons, his daughters, and all the people of his household,
his livestock, all his animals, and all the property he had acquired in
the land of Canaan, and went to a land away from his brother Jacob.
7 Their herds and goods had grown too large for them to stay side
by side, and the country where they were sojourning could not feed
so many animals. 8 So Esau settled in the hill country of Seir. Esau
is Edom.
9 These are the generations of Esau the father of the Edomites in the
hill country of Seir. 10 These are the names of Esau's sons: Eliphaz the
son of Adah the wife of Esau, and Reuel the son of Basemath the wife
of Esau. 11 The sons of Eliphaz were Teman, Omar, Zepho, Gatam, and
Kenaz. 12 Timna, a secondary wife of Eliphaz son of Esau, gave birth
to Amalek[c] for Eliphaz. These were descendants of Adah, Esau's wife.
13 These are the sons of Reuel: Nahath, Zerah, Shammah, and Mizzah.
These are the sons of Basemath, Esau's wife. 14 These are the sons
of Oholibamah the daughter of Anah the daughter of Zibeon, Esau's
wife: she bore to Esau Jeush, Jalam, and Korah.
15 These were the chiefs[d] of the descendants of Esau: the sons of Eli-
phaz, the firstborn of Esau—Chief Teman, Chief Omar, Chief Zepho,

Chief Kenaz, 16 Korah,[e] Gatam, and Amalek. These are the chiefs of
Eliphaz in the land of Edom; these are the sons of Adah. 17 Reuel son of
Esau had these sons: Chief Nahath, Chief Zerah, Chief Shammah, and
Chief Mizzah. They were the chiefs from Reuel in Edom, grandsons
of Basemath, Esau's wife. 18 Oholibamah, Esau's wife, had these sons:
Chief Jeush, Chief Jalam, and Chief Korah. They were the chiefs from
Oholibamah, Anah's daughter, Esau's wife. 19 These are the sons of
Esau (that is, Edom), and these are their chiefs.
20 These are the sons of Seir the Horite,[f] the inhabitants of the land:
Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah, 21 Dishon, Ezer, and Dishan. These are
the chiefs of the Horites, the sons of Seir in the land of Edom. 22 The
sons of Lotan were Hori and Hemam;[g] and Lotan's sister was Timna.
23 These are the sons of Shobal: Alvan, Manahath, Ebal, Shepho, and
Onam. 24 These are the sons of Zibeon: Aiah and Anah. This is the
Anah who found the hot springs[h] in the wilderness, as he pastured
the donkeys of Zibeon his father. 25 These are the children of Anah:
Dishon and Oholibamah the daughter of Anah. 26 These are the sons
of Dishon:[i] Hemdan, Eshban, Ithran, and Cheran. 27 These are the sons
of Ezer: Bilhan, Zaavan, and Akan. 28 These are the sons of Dishan: Uz
and Aran. 29 The Horite chiefs were Chief Lotan, Chief Shobal, Chief
Zibeon, Chief Anah, 30 Chief Dishon, Chief Ezer, and Chief Dishan.
They were the Horite chiefs, clan by clan, in Seir.
31 These are the kings who reigned in the land of Edom, before any
king reigned over the Israelites.[j] 32 Bela the son of Beor reigned in
Edom, and the name of his city was Dinhabah. 33 Bela died, and Jobab
the son of Zerah of Bozrah reigned in his place. 34 Jobab died, and
Husham of the land of the Temanites reigned in his place. 35 Husham
died, and Hadad the son of Bedad, who defeated Midian in the
country of Moab, reigned in his place. The name of his city was Avith.
36 Hadad died, and Samlah of Masrekah reigned in his place. 37 Samlah
died, and Shaul of Rehoboth on the River[k] reigned in his place. 38 Shaul
died, and Baal-hanan the son of Achbor reigned in his place. 39 Baal-
hanan the son of Achbor died, and Hadar[l] reigned in his place. The
name of his city was Pau, and his wife's name was Mehetabel, the
daughter of Matred, the daughter of Mezahab.

40 These are the names of the chiefs descended from Esau, by their families and their places, by name: Chief Timna, Chief Alvah, Chief Jetheth, 41 Chief Oholibamah, Chief Elah, Chief Pinon, 42 Chief Kenaz, Chief Teman, Chief Mibzar, 43 Chief Magdiel, Chief Iram. These are the chiefs of Edom, by their settlements in the land they possessed. This is Esau, the father of Edom.[m]

Notes

- a (36:2) Brenton's Septuagint reads "son of Sebegon," agreeing with 36:24, where Anah is a son of Zibeon. Some other ancient witnesses are reported to read the same.
- b (36:3) Esau's wives are named differently in 26:34 and 28:9 (Judith, Basemath the daughter of Elon, and Mahalath). The traditions may preserve alternate names.
- c (36:12) Amalek became the ancestor of the Amalekites, Israel's enemies (Exodus 17:8–16).
- d (36:15) Hebrew alluph, "chief" or "clan leader." The word may also mean "clan" (compare the note on 36:43).
- e (36:16) Korah is not among the sons of Eliphaz in 36:11 or 1 Chronicles 1:36; he appears as a son of Oholibamah in 36:5, 14, and 18. The Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to lack the name here.
- f (36:20) The Horites were the earlier people of Seir (14:6; Deuteronomy 2:12, 22).
- g (36:22) Called Homam in 1 Chronicles 1:39.
- h (36:24) Hebrew yemim, found only here; the meaning is uncertain. "Hot springs" follows an ancient Latin tradition. Brenton's Septuagint keeps the word untranslated: "who found Jamin in the wilderness."
- i (36:26) Hebrew Dishan, but Dishon in 36:25 and 1 Chronicles 1:41. The two names are close in Hebrew.
- j (36:31) Or "before an Israelite king reigned over them." The note appears to come from a time when Israel already had kings, or it looks ahead to them.
- k (36:37) Probably the Euphrates, though a smaller river nearer Edom may be meant.
- l (36:39) Called Hadad in 1 Chronicles 1:50, and his city Pai. Brenton's Septuagint reads "Arad the son of Barad," and his city "Phogor."
- m (36:43) The list of chiefs in 36:40–43 may name clans or regions as well as persons.

Chapter 37

1 Jacob made his home in Canaan, the country where his father had stayed as a sojourner. 2 These are the generations of Jacob. Joseph, at seventeen years of age, was tending the flock together with his brothers, and he was a youth[a] with the sons of Bilhah and the sons

of Zilpah, his father's wives. Joseph brought a bad report about them to their father.[b] 3 Now Israel loved Joseph more than any of his other sons, because he was the son of his old age. And he made him a long robe with sleeves.[c] 4 But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him.

5 Joseph had a dream, and he told it to his brothers, which made them hate him all the more. 6 He said to them, "Please listen to this dream that I have dreamed: 7 There we were, binding sheaves in the field, and suddenly my sheaf rose and stood upright, and your sheaves gathered around it and bowed down to my sheaf." 8 His brothers answered, "So you think you will be king over us? You will be our master?" And his dreams and what he said about them made them hate him still more.

9 He dreamed still another dream and recounted it to his brothers: "Look, I have had another dream, and this time the sun, the moon, and eleven stars were bowing down to me." 10 When he recounted it to his father and to his brothers, his father scolded him and said, "What kind of dream is this that you have had? Are we really to come, I and your mother[d] and your brothers, and bow down to the ground before you?" 11 His brothers envied him, but his father kept turning the thing over in his mind.

12 Some time later his brothers had gone to graze their father's sheep and goats around Shechem. 13 Israel said to Joseph, "Your brothers are grazing the flock at Shechem, are they not? Come, I am sending you to them." Joseph answered, "I am ready." 14 Israel told him, "Go and find out how your brothers are getting on, and how the flock is, and come back and tell me." So he sent him off from the valley of Hebron, and Joseph arrived at Shechem. 15 A man came upon him as he was roaming about in the open country and asked him, "What are you looking for?" 16 "I am looking for my brothers," he replied. "Can you tell me where they are grazing their flocks?" 17 The man answered, "They have moved on from here. I overheard them saying, 'We will go to Dothan.'" Joseph went on after his brothers and came upon them at Dothan.

18 They saw him from afar, and before he came near to them they
plotted against him to kill him. 19 "Look," they said to each other, "the
dreamer is coming.[e] 20 Now is our chance. We will kill him and toss
his body into one of these cisterns, and say a wild beast ate him. Then
we will find out what his dreams come to!" 21 Reuben heard this and
tried to save him from them. "We must not kill him," he said. 22 "Do not
spill his blood," Reuben told them. "Put him down into this cistern out
here in the desert, but keep your hands off him." He meant to rescue
Joseph from them and bring him back home to his father. 23 When
Joseph reached his brothers, they tore off his coat, the long-sleeved
coat he had on, 24 And they took him and threw him into the pit. The
pit was empty; there was no water in it. 25 They sat down to their
meal. Glancing up, they spotted a line of Ishmaelite traders coming
from Gilead, their camels loaded with gum, balm, and resin,[f] bound
for Egypt. 26 Then Judah said to his brothers, "What profit is it if we
kill our brother and conceal his blood? 27 Come, let us sell him to the
Ishmaelites, and let not our hand be upon him, for he is our brother,
our own flesh." And his brothers listened to him. 28 When Midianite
merchants passed by, his brothers drew Joseph up out of the cistern,
and they sold Joseph to the Ishmaelites for twenty pieces of silver,
about eight ounces.[g] So they brought Joseph to Egypt.
29 When Reuben returned to the pit and saw that Joseph was not in the
pit, he tore his clothes 30 He went back to his brothers and cried, "The
boy is not there! And I, what am I to do now?" 31 They took Joseph's
coat, killed a young goat, and soaked the coat in its blood. 32 They had
the long-sleeved coat carried to their father with the message, "We
came across this. Look closely and see if it is your son's coat."[h] 33 Jacob
knew it at once. "It is my son's coat!" he cried. "Some savage beast
has eaten him. Joseph has surely been torn apart!" 34 Then Jacob tore
his garments and put sackcloth on his waist and mourned for his son
many days. 35 His sons and daughters all came to console him, but he
would not be consoled. "I will go down mourning to my son in Sheol,"[i]
he said. And his father wept for him. 36 In Egypt, meanwhile, the
Midianites[j] sold Joseph to Potiphar, one of Pharaoh's court officials[k]
and commander of the guard.[l]

Notes

- a (37:2) Or "he was an assistant." Hebrew na'ar can mean "youth" or "servant."
- b (37:2) Literally "brought their evil report to their father." Brenton notes that some copies read "they brought an evil report of Joseph."
- c (37:3) Hebrew ketonet passim, also used of a princess's robe in 2 Samuel 13:18–19. Passim may refer to long sleeves or a robe reaching to the hands and feet; its exact meaning is uncertain. Brenton's Septuagint reads "a coat of many colours."
- d (37:10) Rachel had died (35:19). The dream may count her among the family as a whole, or this story may stand apart from the order of chapter 35.
- e (37:19) Literally "this lord of dreams," a mocking expression.
- f (37:25) The precise identity of these resins is uncertain. Brenton's Septuagint reads "spices, and resin, and myrrh," and Brenton notes that one of the Greek words is literally "stacte."
- g (37:28) Hebrew "twenty of silver," that is, twenty shekels (compare Leviticus 27:5), about 8 ounces (230 grams), counting a shekel as about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); weight standards varied. Brenton's Septuagint reads "twenty pieces of gold." The verse names both Midianites and Ishmaelites as traders (compare 37:25, 36; 39:1; Judges 8:24), and it is not clear whether "they" who drew Joseph up were the brothers or the Midianites.
- h (37:32) Hebrew haker-na, "please recognize." The same words return in 38:25, when Tamar confronts Judah.
- i (37:35) Hebrew Sheol, the realm of the dead. Brenton's Septuagint reads "Hades."
- j (37:36) Hebrew Medanim, a variant spelling of Midianites; compare 25:2.
- k (37:36) Hebrew saris, often "eunuch," but also used of a high court officer, married or not (compare 39:1, 7). Brenton's Septuagint reads "the eunuch of Pharao."
- l (37:36) Or "chief of the executioners" or "chief butcher." Brenton notes on 39:1 that the Greek reads "chief cook," and that the Hebrew word can mean either a cook or a guardsman.

Chapter 38

1 At that time Judah left his brothers and went down, and turned aside
to a certain Adullamite whose name was Hirah. 2 There Judah saw
the daughter of a Canaanite whose name was Shua. He took her and
went in to her, 3 and she conceived and bore a son, and he called his
name Er. 4 She conceived again and bore a son, and she called his
name Onan. 5 Once more she bore a son, Shelah. Judah was at Chezib[a]
at the time of his birth. 6 And Judah took a wife for Er his firstborn,
and her name was Tamar. 7 But Er, Judah's firstborn, was wicked in
the sight of Yahweh, and Yahweh put him to death. 8 Then Judah
said to Onan, "Go in to your brother's wife and perform the duty

of a brother-in-law to her,[b] and raise up offspring for your brother."
9 Onan knew that any child would not be counted as his own. So
each time he lay with his brother's wife, he spilled his seed on the
ground, to keep from giving his brother descendants. 10 His conduct
displeased Yahweh, and Yahweh took his life as well. 11 Judah said to
his daughter-in-law Tamar, "Remain a widow in your father's house
until my son Shelah grows up," for he thought, "He too may die, like
his brothers." So Tamar departed and lived in the house of her father.
12 After many days Judah's wife, the daughter of Shua, died. When his
time of mourning was over, Judah went up with his friend Hirah of
Adullam to the men who were shearing his sheep at Timnah. 13 And
when Tamar was told, "Your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to
shear his sheep," 14 she put away her widow's clothing, covered her
face with a veil, wrapped herself, and sat down at the gateway of
Enaim,[c] beside the road to Timnah. She knew that Shelah was grown,
yet she had not been given to him in marriage. 15 When Judah saw
her, he thought she was a prostitute, for she had covered her face. 16
Not knowing that she was his son's wife, he went over to her by the
road and said, "Come, let me sleep with you." She asked, "What will
you pay me to sleep with me?" 17 He said, "I will send you a kid from
the flock." And she said, "Only if you give a pledge until you send
it." 18 He said, "What pledge shall I give you?" She replied, "Your seal
and your cord,[d] and your staff that is in your hand." So he gave them
to her and went in to her, and she conceived by him. 19 She rose and
left. She took off her veil and dressed again in her widow's clothing.
20 Judah sent the young goat by the hand of his friend from Adullam,
to get back the things he had left with the woman, but his friend
could not find her. 21 And he asked the men of the place, "Where is the
shrine woman[e] who was at Enaim by the roadside?" And they said,
"No shrine woman has been here." 22 He went back to Judah and said,
"I did not find her; and the men of the place said, 'There has been
no shrine woman here.'" 23 Judah said, "Then she may keep what she
has, or we will be made fools of. I did send the goat, after all, and you
could not find her."

24 About three months later Judah was told, “Tamar your daughter-
in-law has played the prostitute. Moreover, she is pregnant by her
prostitution.” And Judah said, “Bring her out, and let her be burned.”
25 While she was being brought out, she sent word to her father-in-
law, “By the man who owns these things I am with child.” And she
said, “Look closely[f] and see whose these are, this seal and cord, and
this staff.” 26 Judah knew them and said, “She is more in the right than
I am,[g] because I did not give her to my son Shelah.” He never slept
with her again.
27 When her time to give birth came, it was found that she was
carrying twins. 28 While she was in labor, one child stretched out a
hand; the midwife took a scarlet thread, tied it around his hand, and
said, “This one came out first.” 29 But he pulled his hand back, and
out came his brother. She said, “So you have broken out!” And he
was named Perez.[h] 30 Afterward his brother came out with the scarlet
thread on his hand, and his name was called Zerah.[i]

Notes

- a (38:5) Brenton’s Septuagint reads “she was in Chasbi when she bore them,” with Judah’s wife as the subject. Chezib is probably Achzib in the lowlands of Judah (Joshua 15:44).
- b (38:8) The custom later called levirate marriage, in which a brother married a dead man’s widow to give the dead man an heir (Deuteronomy 25:5–10; Ruth 4).
- c (38:14) Or “in an open place.” Enaim means “two springs” or “eyes”; Hebrew petach enayim can be read “the opening of the eyes.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “by the gates of Ænan.”
- d (38:18) A cylinder or stamp seal worn on a cord around the neck, used to sign documents; the staff likely bore its owner’s marks. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “Thy ring, and thy bracelet, and the staff,” and gives “necklace” as an alternative in his note.
- e (38:21) Hebrew qedeshah, a woman associated with a shrine. Hirah uses this word, which may have sounded more respectable, though Judah had taken her for an ordinary prostitute (zonah, 38:15). Brenton’s Septuagint reads “harlot” in both places.
- f (38:25) The same words used when Jacob was shown Joseph’s robe (37:32). The deceiver of his father is now deceived by a garment and a goat.
- g (38:26) Or “She is in the right, not I.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “Thamar is cleared rather than I.”

- h (38:29) Perez means “breach” or “breaking out.” He became an ancestor of David (Ruth 4:18–22) and appears in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:3).
- i (38:30) Zerah means “rising” or “brightness,” perhaps alluding to the scarlet thread.

Chapter 39

1 Now Joseph had been brought down into Egypt. Potiphar, an Egyptian who served Pharaoh as an official and commander of the guard, bought him from the Ishmaelite traders who had taken him there. 2 Yahweh was with Joseph, and everything went well for him while he lived in the household of his Egyptian master. 3 His master saw that Yahweh was with him and that Yahweh made everything he did succeed in his hands. 4 Joseph won his master’s trust and became his personal servant. Potiphar put him over his household and handed everything he owned into his care. 5 From the time that he made him overseer in his house and over all that he had, Yahweh blessed the Egyptian’s house for Joseph’s sake; the blessing of Yahweh was on all that he had, in house and field. 6 Potiphar left everything he had in Joseph’s hands. With Joseph there, he gave no thought to anything except the bread he ate.[a] Joseph had a fine figure and a handsome face.[b]

7 And after a time his master’s wife cast her eyes on Joseph and said, “Lie with me.” 8 But Joseph refused. “Look,” he told his master’s wife, “my master trusts me so fully that he gives no thought to what goes on in the house. All he owns he has put into my hands. 9 No one in this house is greater than I am, and he has not kept anything from me but you, because you are his wife. How could I then do this great wickedness, and sin against God?” 10 Though she pressed Joseph day after day, he would not give in to her and lie with her, or even be near her. 11 On a certain day he went into the house to do his work, and not one of the men of the household was there inside, 12 she caught him by his garment, saying, “Lie with me.” But he left his garment in her hand and fled and got out of the house. 13 When she saw that he had run outside and left his cloak in her hands, 14 she called the men of her house and said to them, “Look, he has brought in among us a Hebrew man to make sport of us.[c] He came in to me to lie with

me, but I screamed loudly. 15 When he heard me scream for help, he ran outside, leaving his cloak here with me." 16 Then she laid up his garment by her until his master came home, 17 Then she told him her tale: "That Hebrew slave you brought into our house came to me to toy with me. 18 When I screamed for help, he left his cloak with me and ran outside."
19 Joseph's master heard his wife's account, "This is what your slave did to me," and he was furious.[d] 20 And Joseph's master took him and put him into the prison,[e] the place where the king's prisoners were confined, and he was there in prison. 21 Yahweh was with Joseph, extended steadfast love[f] to him, and granted him favor in the eyes of the prison warden. 22 The chief jailer gave Joseph charge over everyone held in the prison, so that Joseph saw to everything that was done there. 23 The chief jailer did not trouble himself about anything under Joseph's care, for Yahweh was with Joseph and gave success to all he did.

Notes

- a (39:6) Literally "except the bread that he ate." This may mean that Potiphar kept charge of his own food, perhaps for reasons of Egyptian purity (compare 43:32), or it may be a euphemism for his wife (compare 39:9).
- b (39:6) The same words are used of Rachel, Joseph's mother, in 29:17. Brenton's Septuagint reads "handsome in form, and exceedingly beautiful in countenance."
- c (39:14) Hebrew letsacheq, from the same root as Isaac's name. Here it carries a sexual sense (compare 26:8). Brenton's Septuagint reads "to mock us."
- d (39:19) The text does not say against whom his anger burned. That Joseph was imprisoned rather than executed may suggest that Potiphar had doubts.
- e (39:20) Literally "the round house," a word used only in this story (39:20–40:5). It may refer to a fortress prison.
- f (39:21) Hebrew chesed, loyal love. Brenton's Septuagint reads "poured down mercy upon him."

Chapter 40

1 After a while, two servants of the king of Egypt, his cupbearer and his baker, gave offense to their master, the king. 2 Pharaoh was enraged at these two officials, his chief cupbearer and his chief baker. 3 and he put them in custody in the house of the captain of the guard, in the prison where Joseph was confined. 4 The commander of the

guard assigned them to Joseph, who waited on them. They had been held there for some time [5] when the two of them, the king of Egypt's cupbearer and baker who were held in the prison, both had dreams on the same night. Each man had his own dream, and each dream had its own meaning. [6] Joseph came in to them the next morning and saw that they looked downcast. [7] So he asked Pharaoh's officers who were with him in custody in his master's house, "Why are your faces downcast today?" [8] They told him, "Each of us has had a dream, and nobody can explain it." Joseph said, "Is it not God who explains dreams? Tell me about them."

[9] The chief cupbearer told Joseph his dream. "I dreamed," he said, "that a grapevine stood in front of me, [10] with three branches on it. As soon as it put out buds, it burst into flower, and its bunches grew ripe grapes. [11] Pharaoh's cup was in my hand, and I took the grapes and pressed them into Pharaoh's cup and placed the cup in Pharaoh's hand." [12] Then Joseph said to him, "This is its interpretation: the three branches are three days. [13] Within three days Pharaoh will lift up your head[a] and put you back in your post. You will hand Pharaoh his cup again, as you used to do when you were his cupbearer. [14] But when things go well for you, think of me. Be kind to me, speak of me to Pharaoh, and get me released from this place. [15] For I was indeed stolen out of the land of the Hebrews, and here also I have done nothing that they should put me into the pit."[b]

[16] When the chief baker saw that the interpretation was favorable, he said to Joseph, "I also had a dream: there were three baskets of white bread[c] on my head, [17] In the top basket were baked goods of every kind for Pharaoh, but birds kept eating them out of the basket on my head." [18] And Joseph answered and said, "This is its interpretation: the three baskets are three days. [19] Within three days Pharaoh will lift your head off you and hang you from a tree,[d] and the birds will eat the flesh from you."

[20] On the third day, Pharaoh's birthday, he held a banquet for all his servants, and in the presence of his servants he lifted up the head of the chief cupbearer and the head of the chief baker. [21] He put the chief cupbearer back in his post, and the cupbearer once again

handed Pharaoh his cup. 22 But he hanged the chief baker, as Joseph had interpreted to them. 23 But the chief cupbearer gave no thought to Joseph. He forgot all about him.

Notes

- a (40:13) An idiom for showing favor or for pardoning; also used of taking a census or a count. In 40:19 the phrase is turned grimly, "lift up your head from you," and in 40:20 it is used in both senses at once.
- b (40:15) Hebrew bor, "pit" or "dungeon," the same word used of the pit into which his brothers threw him (37:24).
- c (40:16) Or "baskets of white wicker" or "baskets with holes." The meaning of Hebrew chori is uncertain. Brenton's Septuagint reads "three baskets of mealy food."
- d (40:19) Or "impale you on a stake." The body was displayed after death (compare Deuteronomy 21:22–23). Brenton's Septuagint reads "hang thee on a tree."

Chapter 41

1 When two full years[a] had gone by, Pharaoh had a dream. He was standing beside the Nile,[b] 2 and seven cows, attractive and fat, came up out of the Nile and grazed among the reeds.[c] 3 After them seven more cows came up from the river, wretched and lean, and they stood next to the first cows at the water's edge. 4 The wretched, lean cows devoured the seven sleek, well-fed cows. Then Pharaoh woke up. 5 He went back to sleep and had a second dream. Seven heads of grain, full and fine, grew up on a single stem. 6 Behind them seven more heads came up, shriveled and burned by the east wind.[d] 7 The thin ears devoured the seven plump and full ears. Then Pharaoh woke, and behold, it was a dream. 8 So in the morning his spirit was troubled, and he sent and called for all the magicians[e] of Egypt and all its wise men. Pharaoh told them his dreams, but there was no one who could interpret them to Pharaoh.

9 The chief cupbearer spoke up and said to Pharaoh, "Today I must call to mind my faults. 10 Pharaoh was furious with his servants, and he put me and the chief baker under guard in the house of the captain of the guard, 11 One night each of us had a dream, he and I, and each dream carried its own meaning. 12 There was a Hebrew youth in that place with us, a slave of the commander of the guard. We told him our dreams, and he explained them, telling each of us what his own

dream meant. 13 It all turned out just as he explained it to us. I was
given back my post, and the other man was hanged."
14 Pharaoh sent for Joseph, and they hurried him out of the dungeon.
He shaved, put on fresh clothing, and came into Pharaoh's presence.
15 And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "I have had a dream, and there is no
one who can interpret it. I have heard it said of you that when you
hear a dream you can interpret it." 16 Joseph answered Pharaoh, "It is
not in me. God will give Pharaoh an answer of peace."[f] 17 Pharaoh told
Joseph, "In my dream I stood on the riverbank of the Nile. 18 Seven
cows, fat and attractive, came up out of the Nile and grazed among the
reeds. 19 Then seven other cows came up behind them, feeble and very
ugly and thin, worse than any I had ever seen in all the land of Egypt.
20 And the lean and ugly cows ate up the first seven fat cows, 21 Yet
after they had swallowed them, no one could tell they had swallowed
anything. They looked as wretched as before. Then I woke up. 22 In
my dream I saw too seven heads of grain, full and fine, coming up on
a single stem. 23 Behind them seven more heads sprang up, shrunken,
lean, and burned by the east wind, 24 and the thin ears swallowed up
the seven good ears. And I told it to the magicians, but there was no
one who could explain it to me."
25 Joseph told Pharaoh, "Pharaoh's two dreams have one meaning.
God has made known to Pharaoh what he is going to do. 26 The seven
good cows are seven years, and the seven good ears are seven years;
the dreams are one. 27 The seven thin and ugly cows that rose up
behind them are seven years, and the seven ears, empty and scorched
by the east wind, will be seven years of famine. 28 That is what I meant
when I said to Pharaoh that God has let Pharaoh see what he is going
to do. 29 There will come seven years of great plenty throughout all the
land of Egypt, 30 but seven years of famine will follow them, and all
the plenty will be forgotten in the land of Egypt; and the famine will
devour the land, 31 The famine that follows will be so harsh that no
one will remember the good years in the land. 32 Pharaoh was given
the dream twice because God has firmly decided the matter, and God
will soon carry it out. 33 So now Pharaoh should look for a man of
understanding and wisdom and put him in charge of Egypt. 34 Pharaoh

should also name officials throughout the land and collect a fifth of Egypt's harvest in the seven years of plenty.[g] 35 They should gather all the food of the good years ahead and pile up grain in the towns under Pharaoh's control, and guard it there as food. 36 This food will be held in store for the country, ready for the seven years of famine that will come upon Egypt, and the land will not be ruined by the famine."
37 This proposal pleased Pharaoh and all his servants. 38 Pharaoh asked his officials, "Could we ever find another man like this, who has the spirit of God in him?"[h] 39 And Pharaoh told Joseph, "God has made all this known to you, so no one else has your understanding and wisdom. 40 You shall be over my house, and all my people shall be ruled by your word.[i] Only as regards the throne will I be greater than you." 41 And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "See, I have set you over all the land of Egypt." 42 Pharaoh removed his signet ring from his own hand and placed it on Joseph's hand; he dressed him in robes of fine linen and hung a chain of gold around his neck. 43 He had Joseph ride in the chariot of his second-in-command, and men shouted before him, "Abrek!"[j] In this way Pharaoh put him over the whole land of Egypt. 44 Pharaoh told Joseph, "I am Pharaoh. But no one in all Egypt will move hand or foot unless you allow it." 45 Pharaoh gave Joseph the name Zaphenath-paneah.[k] He also gave him as wife Asenath,[l] daughter of Potiphera, priest of On.[m] And Joseph went forth over the land of Egypt.
46 Joseph was thirty years old when he took up his post before Pharaoh, king of Egypt. He left Pharaoh's presence and traveled throughout Egypt. 47 During the seven plentiful years the earth produced abundantly, 48 Joseph collected all the food grown in Egypt during those seven years and stored it in the towns, placing in each town the food from the fields that surrounded it. 49 The grain Joseph piled up was beyond counting, like the sand of the sea. In the end he gave up keeping records, because there was too much to measure.
50 Two sons were born to Joseph before the years of famine began. Their mother was Asenath, daughter of Potiphera, the priest of On. 51 Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh. "For," he said, "God has made me forget all my hardship and all my father's house."[n] 52 The

name of the second he called Ephraim, "For God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction."[o]
53 The seven years of plenty that had been in the land of Egypt ended, 54
and the seven years of famine began to arrive, just as Joseph had said.
Famine struck every land, but throughout the land of Egypt there was
bread. 55 When the whole land of Egypt grew hungry, the people cried
out to Pharaoh for bread, and Pharaoh told all the Egyptians, "Go to
Joseph; do whatever he tells you." 56 When famine covered the whole
land, Joseph unsealed all the stores[p] and sold grain to the Egyptians,
for the famine grew harsh in Egypt. 57 People from every land came to
Joseph in Egypt to buy grain, since the famine was harsh throughout
the world.

Notes

- a (41:1) Literally "two years of days." Brenton notes the same idiom in the Greek.
- b (41:1) Hebrew ye'or, an Egyptian word for the Nile or its channels. Brenton's Septuagint reads "the river."
- c (41:2) Hebrew achu, an Egyptian loanword for marsh grass, found also in Job 8:11. Brenton notes that the Septuagint keeps the word in Greek letters; his text renders it "sedge."
- d (41:6) The hot, dry wind from the desert, called the khamsin.
- e (41:8) Hebrew chartummim, an Egyptian loanword for priestly scholars skilled in sacred writings and magic (compare Exodus 7:11). Brenton's Septuagint reads "interpreters."
- f (41:16) Literally "God will answer the peace (shalom) of Pharaoh," that is, an answer for his welfare. Brenton's Septuagint reads "Without God an answer of safety shall not be given to Pharao."
- g (41:34) Or "organize the land." The verb may mean "take a fifth" or more generally "prepare." Brenton's Septuagint reads "take up a fifth part."
- h (41:38) Or "a spirit of the gods." Pharaoh, as an Egyptian, may mean it in the second sense. Brenton's Septuagint reads "the Spirit of God."
- i (41:40) Literally "at your mouth all my people shall kiss." The meaning is uncertain; it may mean "do homage" or "be ruled." Brenton notes that the Greek has "mouth," and his text reads "all my people shall be obedient to thy word."
- j (41:43) Probably an Egyptian word, perhaps meaning "Attention!" or "Make way!" though it sounds like a Hebrew word for "kneel." Brenton's Septuagint reads "a herald made proclamation before him."
- k (41:45) Probably an Egyptian name meaning "God speaks and he lives" or "the one who is called life." Brenton's Septuagint reads "Psonthomphanech."

- l (41:45) Asenath probably means “belonging to Neith,” an Egyptian goddess. The later Greek work Joseph and Aseneth tells of her conversion.
- m (41:45) On is Heliopolis, a center of sun worship, near modern Cairo. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “priest of Heliopolis.” Potiphera, “the one whom Ra has given,” is a fuller form of Potiphar.
- n (41:51) Manasseh sounds like nashshani, “he has made me forget.”
- o (41:52) Ephraim sounds like hiphrani, “he has made me fruitful.”
- p (41:56) Literally “all that was in them”; the Hebrew lacks a noun. Brenton’s Septuagint reads “all the granaries.”

Chapter 42

1 Jacob heard that grain could be bought in Egypt, and he said to his
sons, “Why do you just stand there staring at each other?” 2 He told
them, “I hear there is grain in Egypt. Go down there and buy some
for us, so that we can stay alive and not starve.” 3 So ten of Joseph’s
brothers went down to buy grain in Egypt. 4 Jacob would not let
Benjamin, Joseph’s full brother, go along with the others, for fear that
something might befall him. 5 The sons of Israel were among those
coming to buy, for the famine had come upon the land of Canaan
as well.
6 Now Joseph governed the land, and he was the one selling grain to
everyone who came. Joseph’s brothers came and bowed low before
him, faces to the ground. 7 Joseph knew his brothers the moment he
saw them, but he acted as a stranger[a] and spoke harshly. “Where are
you from?” he asked. “From Canaan,” they replied, “to buy food.” 8
And Joseph recognized his brothers, but they did not recognize him.
9 Joseph called to mind the dreams he had had about them. “You are
spies!” he told them. “You came to find where our land lies open.”[b]
10 They said to him, “No, my lord, your servants have come to buy
food. 11 We are all sons of one man. We are honest men. Your servants
have never been spies.” 12 “Not so,” he told them. “You came to find
where our land lies open.” 13 And they said, “We, your servants, are
twelve brothers, the sons of one man in the land of Canaan, and the
youngest is now with our father, and one is no more.” 14 But Joseph
answered, “What I said to you stands. You are spies! 15 In this way
you will be tested: by the life of Pharaoh,[c] you shall not leave here
unless your youngest brother comes. 16 Send one of your number back

for your brother, and the rest of you stay here in chains. Your words will be put to the proof, to show whether there is any truth in you. Otherwise, by Pharaoh's life, you are spies!" 17 Then he locked them all up under guard for three days.
18 On the third day Joseph told them, "I fear God. Do as I say, and you will live. 19 If you are honest men, let one brother stay behind, bound in the prison where you are held, while the others go home with grain for your hungry families. 20 Then bring your youngest brother back to me. That will prove your words true, and you will not die." They agreed to this. 21 They said to one another, "We are surely being punished for what we did to our brother. We saw how he suffered when he pleaded with us for mercy, and we would not listen. That is why this suffering has come upon us." 22 Reuben answered them, "Did I not warn you, 'Do no wrong to the boy'? But you would not hear me. And now his blood is being demanded of us."[d] 23 They did not know that Joseph understood them, for there was an interpreter between them. 24 Joseph turned aside from them and wept. Then he came back and talked with them, and he had Simeon taken from among them and tied up while they watched. 25 Joseph gave orders for their bags to be filled with grain, for the silver of each one to be returned to his own sack, and for food to be supplied for the journey. And it was done for them.
26 Then they loaded their donkeys with their grain and departed. 27 At the lodging place[e] one of them unfastened his sack to give his donkey fodder, and he saw his money—there it was in the mouth of his sack. 28 "My silver has been returned!" he called to his brothers. "Look, it is right here in my sack!" Their hearts sank. Shaking, they looked at each other and said, "What has God done to us?"
29 When they came to Jacob their father in the land of Canaan, they told him all that had happened to them, saying, 30 "The man, the lord of the land, spoke roughly to us and took us to be spies of the land. 31 But we said to him, 'We are honest men; we have never been spies. 32 We are twelve brothers, sons of our father. One is no more, and the youngest is this day with our father in the land of Canaan.' 33 The man who is lord of the land said to us, 'This is how I will know that you

are honest: leave one of your brothers with me, take food for your starving households, and be on your way. 34 Bring me your youngest brother, and then I will know that you are no spies but honest men. I will give your brother back to you, and you may do business in the land.'" 35 As they emptied their sacks, there was each man's bundle of money in his sack. And when they and their father saw their bundles of money, they were afraid. 36 Jacob their father said to them, "You have taken my children from me. Joseph is lost, Simeon is lost, and now you would carry off Benjamin. All these things fall on me!" 37 Reuben told his father, "If I fail to bring him home to you, you may put my own two sons to death. Leave him in my care, and I will bring him back." 38 Jacob answered, "No, my son is not going with you. His brother is dead and only he remains. Should any harm come to him on the way, you would bring my gray head down to Sheol in sorrow."[f]

Notes

- a (42:7) Hebrew wayyitnakker, "he made himself a stranger," a play on wayyakkirem, "he recognized them," in the same verse.
- b (42:9) That is, the weak and unguarded places of the land. Brenton's Septuagint reads "to observe the marks of the land are ye come."
- c (42:15) An oath formula. Brenton's Septuagint reads "by the health of Pharao."
- d (42:22) Literally "his blood is required." Compare 9:5–6.
- e (42:27) Hebrew malon, a place to spend the night, not necessarily a building.
- f (42:38) Hebrew Sheol; see the note on 37:35. Brenton's Septuagint reads "bring down my old age with sorrow to Hades."

Chapter 43

1 Now the famine was severe in the land. 2 When the grain they had brought from Egypt was used up, their father told them, "Go back down and buy us a little more food." 3 Judah said to him, "The man gave us a solemn warning: 'You will not see my face unless your brother is with you.' 4 If you will send our brother with us, we will go down and buy you food. 5 But if you will not send him, we will not go down, for the man said to us, 'You shall not see my face, unless your brother is with you.'" 6 Israel said, "Why did you bring this trouble on me by telling the man that you still had a brother?" 7 They said, "The man questioned us closely about ourselves and our

kin. He asked, 'Is your father alive? Do you have another brother?' We simply answered what he asked. How could we know he would say, 'Bring your brother down here'?" 8 And Judah said to Israel his father, "Send the boy with me, and we will get up and go, so that we may live and not die, both we and you and also our little ones. 9 I myself will be surety for him;[a] you may demand him at my hand. If I do not bring him to you and set him in your presence, I will have sinned against you all my days. 10 Had we not wasted all this time, we could have gone there and back twice by now."

11 Then Israel their father said to them, "If it must be so, then do this: put some of the choicest produce of the land in your containers and take a present down to the man—some balm, some honey, resin, myrrh, pistachio nuts, and almonds.[b] 12 Take twice the silver with you, and take back the silver that was put back in the openings of your sacks. It may have been a mistake. 13 Take also your brother, and get up, go again to the man. 14 May El Shaddai[c] give you mercy in the man's sight, so that he releases your other brother to you, and Benjamin too. And I, if I am to be bereaved, then bereaved I will be." 15 So the men took the gifts, twice the amount of silver, and Benjamin. They set off for Egypt and presented themselves to Joseph.

16 When Joseph saw Benjamin with them, he said to the steward of his house, "Bring the men into the house, and kill an animal and get it ready, for the men are going to eat with me at noon." 17 The steward followed Joseph's orders and took the men into Joseph's house. 18 The men grew frightened when they were taken to Joseph's house. "We are being brought in here because of the silver that went back into our sacks the last time," they said. "He wants to attack us, overpower us, make slaves of us, and take our donkeys." 19 So at the entrance of the house they went up to Joseph's steward and spoke to him. 20 and said, "Please, my lord, we came down the first time to buy food. 21 But when we stopped for the night and opened our sacks, every man found his own silver in the top of his sack, the full weight of it. Now we have brought it back with us. 22 We have brought more silver as well, to buy food. We have no idea who put our silver back in our sacks." 23 "All is well,[d]" he said. "There is nothing to fear. It was your

God, the God of your father, who placed treasure in your sacks for you. Your silver reached me." Then he brought Simeon out to them. 24 The steward took the men into Joseph's house. He gave them water to wash their feet and gave feed to their donkeys. 25 they prepared the present for Joseph's coming at noon, for they heard that they should eat bread there.
26 When Joseph came home, they brought him the present that was in their hands into the house, and bowed down to the ground before him. 27 And he inquired about their welfare and said, "Is your father well, the old man of whom you spoke? Is he still alive?" 28 They answered, "Your servant our father is in good health; he is still living." And they bent low and bowed down. 29 Looking up, he saw his brother Benjamin, his mother's son, and asked, "Is this your youngest brother, the one you told me about?" And he said, "May God be gracious to you, my son." 30 Joseph hurried away, deeply stirred at the sight of his brother, and looked for somewhere to weep. He went to his private room and wept there. 31 After washing his face he came out again. Holding himself in check, he said, "Bring in the meal." 32 They set a place for him by himself, for them by themselves, and for the Egyptians who ate with him by themselves, because Egyptians could not eat bread with Hebrews; it is an abomination to Egypt.[e] 33 And they sat before him, the firstborn according to his birthright and the youngest according to his youth. And the men looked at one another in amazement. 34 Joseph had servings carried to them from his own table, and Benjamin's serving was five times larger than anyone else's.[f] So they feasted and drank freely with him.[g]

Notes

- a (43:9) Hebrew e'ervennu, "I will be his guarantor." Judah offers himself as guarantor; he later fulfills this pledge in 44:32–34.
- b (43:11) Several of these items appear in 37:25 as the goods of the traders who carried Joseph to Egypt. Brenton's Septuagint lists "gum and honey, and frankincense, and stacte, and turpentine, and walnuts."
- c (43:14) Traditionally "God Almighty"; see the note on El Shaddai at 17:1. Brenton's Septuagint reads "my God."
- d (43:23) Hebrew shalom lakhem, a greeting that also reassures: "All is well with you." Brenton's Septuagint reads "God deal mercifully with you," and Brenton

explains the steward's last words as meaning that he was satisfied with the money paid.

- e (43:32) Greek historians also report that Egyptians avoided eating with foreigners. Compare 46:34.
- f (43:34) Literally "five hands," meaning five times as much. Brenton notes that the Greek says it "was magnified beyond the portions of all five times."
- g (43:34) Literally "drank and became drunk with him," that is, drank freely.

Chapter 44

1 He ordered the steward of his house, "Fill the sacks of the men with
food, as much as they can carry, and put each man's money in the
mouth of his sack, 2 Put my cup, the silver one, in the top of the
youngest one's sack, along with the silver he paid for his grain." The
steward did what Joseph said. 3 As soon as the morning was light, the
men were sent away with their donkeys. 4 They were not far from the
city when Joseph told his steward, "Go after those men at once. When
you catch up with them, ask them, 'Why have you paid back good
with evil? 5 Is this not the cup my lord drinks from, the one he uses to
read omens?[a] What you have done is wicked.'" 6 When he overtook
them, he spoke to them these words. 7 They said to him, "Why does
my lord speak such words as these? Far be it from your servants to do
such a thing! 8 Why, we even brought back to you from Canaan the
silver we found in the tops of our sacks. Why would we steal silver or
gold from your master's house? 9 If any of us, your servants, is found
to have it, he must die, and the rest of us will be slaves to my lord." 10
"Very well, then," he said, "as you say. But only the one who is found
with it will be my slave. The rest of you will go free." 11 Then each
man quickly lowered his sack to the ground, and each man opened
his sack. 12 He began the search with the oldest and finished with the
youngest, and the cup turned up in Benjamin's sack. 13 They ripped
their garments in grief. Each man loaded his donkey again, and they
went back to the city.

14 Joseph was still at home when Judah and his brothers arrived, and
they threw themselves on the ground before him. 15 Joseph asked
them, "What have you done? Surely you knew that a man such as I
can read omens?" 16 Judah said, "What can we say to my lord? How

can we speak, and how can we prove ourselves innocent? God has uncovered the guilt of your servants. See, we are my lord's servants, we and the one in whose hand the cup was found." 17 But Joseph said, "I would never do that! Only the man who had the cup will be my slave. The rest of you may return in peace to your father."
18 Then Judah approached him and said, "Pardon me, my lord; permit your servant to say a word in the ears of my lord, and let your wrath not burn hot against your servant, for you are as Pharaoh. 19 My lord asked his servants, saying, 'Have you a father, or a brother?' 20 We said to my lord, 'We have a father, an old man, and a young child born in his old age. His brother is dead, and he alone is left of his mother, and his father loves him.' 21 Then you said to your servants, 'Bring him down to me, that I may set my eyes on him.' 22 We said to my lord, 'The boy cannot leave his father, for if he should leave his father, his father would die.' 23 But you told your servants, 'Your youngest brother must come down with you, or you will never see my face again.' 24 When we went back to your servant my father, we told him the words of my lord. 25 And when our father said, 'Go again, buy us a little food,' 26 we said, 'We are not able to go down. If our youngest brother is with us, then we shall go down, for we cannot see the man's face unless our youngest brother is with us.' 27 Then your servant my father said to us, 'You know that my wife bore me two sons. 28 The one went out from me, and I said, "Surely he has been torn to pieces," and I have not seen him since. 29 If you take this one from me too, and some harm befalls him, you will bring my gray head down to Sheol in misery.'[b] 30 So now, when I go to my father, your servant, and the boy is not with us, since his life is bound up with the boy's life,[c] then, 31 as soon as he sees that the boy is not with us, he will die, and your servants will bring down the gray hairs of your servant our father with sorrow to Sheol. 32 Your servant gave my father a pledge for the boy's safety. I said, 'If I fail to bring him home to you, I will bear the guilt before my father all my days.' 33 So now, I pray, let your servant stay instead of the boy as a slave to my lord, and let the boy go up with his brothers.[d] 34 How could I go back up to my father without the boy? I could not bear to see the misery it would bring on my father."

Notes

- a (44:5) Divination by cup was practiced by watching the patterns of oil or other liquids on water. Joseph may only be claiming the power to keep up his disguise (compare 44:15). Brenton's Septuagint adds at the start of this verse, "Why have ye stolen my silver cup?"
- b (44:29) Hebrew Sheol; see the note on 37:35. Brenton's Septuagint reads "to the grave," and Brenton notes that the Greek is "Hades." The same applies in 44:31.
- c (44:30) Literally "his soul is bound up with his soul." Compare the language of love in 1 Samuel 18:1.
- d (44:33) Judah, who once proposed selling Joseph as a slave (37:26–27), now offers himself as a slave in place of Rachel's other son.

Chapter 45

1 Joseph could no longer keep control of himself before everyone
standing around him. "Have them all leave my presence!" he called
out. So none of them were there with him when Joseph revealed
himself to his brothers. 2 His weeping was so loud that the Egyptians
heard it, and the news reached Pharaoh's house. 3 Joseph told his
brothers, "I am Joseph! Is my father still living?" His brothers could
not answer him, for they were dismayed at his presence. 4 "Please
come closer," Joseph told them, and they came closer. "I am Joseph,
your brother," he said, "the one you sold to be taken to Egypt. 5 Now
do not be grieved, and do not let it burn in your eyes that you sold me
here, for God sent me before you to preserve life. 6 Two years now the
famine has gripped the land, and five more years are coming when no
one will plow or reap. 7 God sent me here before you to make sure you
would have descendants left on the earth, and to save your lives in a
great deliverance.[a] 8 So it was not you who sent me here, but God. He
has made me a father to Pharaoh,[b] and lord of all his house and ruler
over all the land of Egypt. 9 Go quickly back to my father and tell him,
'Your son Joseph says this: God has made me master over all Egypt.
Come down to me without waiting. 10 You will settle in the region
of Goshen[c] and be close to me, you, your sons, and your grandsons,
with your sheep and cattle and everything you own. 11 I will take care
of you there, for five years of famine are still ahead. Otherwise you
and your family and all that is yours will be reduced to want.' 12 And
now your eyes see, and the eyes of my brother Benjamin see, that

it is my mouth that speaks to you. 13 Tell my father how greatly I
am honored in Egypt, and tell him everything you have seen. Then
bring my father down here quickly." 14 Then he fell upon his brother
Benjamin's neck and wept, and Benjamin wept upon his neck. 15 He
kissed each of his brothers and wept over them; and afterward his
brothers spoke with him.
16 The news reached Pharaoh's house: "Joseph's brothers have come."
And it was good in the eyes of Pharaoh and of his servants. 17 Pharaoh
told Joseph, "Give your brothers these orders: 'Load up your animals
and return to Canaan. 18 Bring your father and your households to
me, and I will give you the best part of Egypt's land; you shall eat
the fat of the land.' 19 And you are ordered to do this: take wagons out
of the land of Egypt for your little ones and your wives, and bring
your father and come. 20 Do not worry about leaving your belongings
behind, for the finest of all Egypt will be yours.'" 21 The sons of Israel
did so. Joseph gave them wagons at Pharaoh's command, and he also
gave them food for the road. 22 He gave every one of them a new set
of clothes, but to Benjamin he gave three hundred pieces of silver,
about seven and a half pounds, and five sets of clothes.[d] 23 He sent to
his father these things: ten donkeys carrying the best goods of Egypt,
and ten female donkeys carrying grain, bread, and food for his father
along the way. 24 Thus he dismissed his brothers, and they set out; he
said to them, "Do not fall out with one another[e] on the road."
25 So they went up out of Egypt and came to the land of Canaan to
their father Jacob. 26 And they told him, "Joseph is still alive, and he
is ruler over all the land of Egypt." And Jacob's heart went numb,[f]
for he did not believe them. 27 But when they told him all the words of
Joseph, which he had said to them, and when he saw the wagons that
Joseph had sent to carry him, the spirit of their father Jacob revived.
28 And Israel said, "It is enough; Joseph my son is still alive. I will go
and see him before I die."

Notes

- a (45:7) Or "to keep alive for you many survivors." The words "remnant" and "survivors" later become key words in the prophets for those whom God preserves.

- b (45:8) A title for a chief adviser of the king; compare Egyptian titles such as "father of the god." Brenton's Septuagint reads "as a father of Pharao."
- c (45:10) Goshen was in the eastern Nile Delta. Brenton's Septuagint reads "the land of Gesem of Arabia."
- d (45:22) Hebrew "three hundred of silver," that is, three hundred shekels, about 7½ pounds (3.4 kilograms), counting a shekel as about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); weight standards varied. Brenton's Septuagint reads "three hundred pieces of gold." Compare 37:28, where Joseph was sold for twenty pieces of silver.
- e (45:24) Or "do not be agitated" or "do not be afraid." The Hebrew verb ragaz means to tremble, whether with anger or fear. Brenton's Septuagint reads "Be not angry by the way."
- f (45:26) Literally "his heart grew cold." Brenton notes that the Greek reads "amazed in mind."

Chapter 46

1 So Israel set out with all that he had and came to Beersheba, and
offered sacrifices to the God of his father Isaac. 2 And God spoke to
Israel in visions of the night and said, "Jacob, Jacob." And he said,
"Here I am." 3 He said, "I am God,[a] your father's God. Have no fear of
going down into Egypt, for I will make a great nation of you there. 4
I will go down to Egypt with you myself, and I will bring you back
up again without fail. And Joseph's own hand will close your eyes." 5
Jacob left Beersheba, and the sons of Israel carried their father Jacob,
with their little ones and their wives, in the wagons that Pharaoh had
sent for his transport. 6 They took their cattle and the possessions they
had acquired in the land of Canaan, and they entered Egypt, Jacob
and all his offspring with him, 7 his sons and his sons' sons with him,
his daughters and his sons' daughters; he brought all his offspring
with him to Egypt.
8 These are the names of the sons of Israel who came to Egypt
—Jacob and his sons: Reuben, Jacob's firstborn, 9 and the sons of
Reuben: Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi. 10 The sons of Simeon:
Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar, and Shaul, the son of a Canaanite
woman.[b] 11 The sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari. 12 The
sons of Judah: Er, Onan, Shelah, Perez, and Zerah (but Er and Onan
died in the land of Canaan); and the sons of Perez were Hezron and
Hamul. 13 The sons of Issachar: Tola, Puvah, Yob,[c] and Shimron. 14 The

sons of Zebulun: Sered, Elon, and Jahleel. 15 These are the sons of Leah, born to Jacob in Paddan-aram, along with his daughter Dinah; the total of his sons and daughters was thirty-three.[d] 16 The sons of Gad: Ziphion, Haggi, Shuni, Ezbon, Eri, Arodi, and Areli. 17 The sons of Asher: Imnah, Ishvah, Ishvi, and Beriah, with Serah their sister. The sons of Beriah: Heber and Malchiel. 18 These are the sons of Zilpah, whom Laban gave to Leah his daughter; and these she bore to Jacob, sixteen persons. 19 The sons of Rachel, Jacob's wife: Joseph and Benjamin. 20 And to Joseph in the land of Egypt were born Manasseh and Ephraim, whom Asenath, the daughter of Potiphera the priest of On, bore to him.[e] 21 And the sons of Benjamin: Bela, Becher, Ashbel, Gera, Naaman, Ehi, Rosh, Muppim, Huppim, and Ard.[f] 22 These are the sons of Rachel, who were born to Jacob, fourteen persons in all. 23 The son[g] of Dan: Hushim. 24 The sons of Naphtali: Jahzeel, Guni, Jezer, and Shillem. 25 These are the sons of Bilhah, whom Laban gave to Rachel his daughter, and these she bore to Jacob, seven persons in all. 26 All the persons who came with Jacob into Egypt, his own offspring,[h] apart from the wives of Jacob's sons, numbered sixty-six persons. 27 Joseph's sons, who were born to him in Egypt, numbered two. In all, the persons of the house of Jacob who came to Egypt numbered seventy.[i]

28 Jacob sent Judah on ahead to Joseph, so that Joseph could guide him to Goshen.[j] And they arrived in the region of Goshen. 29 Then Joseph prepared his chariot and went up to meet Israel his father in Goshen. He presented himself to him and fell on his neck and wept on his neck a good while. 30 Israel said to Joseph, "Now let me die, since I have seen your face and know that you are still alive." 31 Joseph said to his brothers and to his father's household, "I will go up and tell Pharaoh and will say to him, 'My brothers and my father's household, who were in the land of Canaan, have come to me. 32 And the men are shepherds, for they have been keepers of livestock, and they have brought their flocks and their herds and all that they have.' 33 So when Pharaoh summons you and asks, 'What work do you do?' 34 you shall say, 'Your servants have been herdsmen from our youth until now,

we and our fathers alike,' so that you may settle in the land of Goshen, for every shepherd is an abomination to the Egyptians."[k]

Notes

- a (46:3) Hebrew ha'el, "the God," or "El." Brenton's Septuagint reads "I am the God of thy fathers."
- b (46:10) The lists of Simeon's sons in Numbers 26:12–13 and 1 Chronicles 4:24 differ: Jemuel is called Nemuel there, and Ohad is not named.
- c (46:13) Called Jashub in Numbers 26:24 and 1 Chronicles 7:1, and some ancient witnesses are reported to read Jashub here as well.
- d (46:15) The total includes Jacob himself and Dinah, but not Er and Onan, who had died (compare 46:12).
- e (46:20) Brenton's Septuagint adds here the sons of Manasseh and Ephraim: "Machir. And Machir begot Galaad," and "Sutalaam, and Taam. And the sons of Sutalaam; Edom." Compare Numbers 26:29–36.
- f (46:21) Brenton's Septuagint arranges this list differently, making Gera, Noeman, Anchis, Ros, and Mamphim sons of Bela, and adding "Gera begot Arad." Compare Numbers 26:38–40 and 1 Chronicles 8:1–5.
- g (46:23) Hebrew "sons," although only one is named. Called Shuham in Numbers 26:42.
- h (46:26) Literally "who came out from his thigh." Brenton notes that the Greek reads "thighs."
- i (46:27) Brenton's Septuagint reads "The sons of Joseph… were nine souls" and gives the total as "seventy-five souls," counting the descendants it adds in 46:20. Stephen follows this number in Acts 7:14, and some other ancient witnesses are reported to read seventy-five in Exodus 1:5 as well. Seventy is the number of the nations in chapter 10.
- j (46:28) Brenton's Septuagint reads "to meet him to the city of Heroes, into the land of Ramesses." Heroopolis was a city in the eastern Nile Delta.
- k (46:34) Compare 43:32. Joseph's advice keeps his family apart in Goshen, where they can remain a distinct people.

Chapter 47

1 Joseph went to Pharaoh and told him, "My father and brothers have
arrived from Canaan with their sheep and cattle and all their goods.
They are in the region of Goshen now." 2 And from among his brothers
he took five men and presented them to Pharaoh. 3 Pharaoh said to his
brothers, "What is your occupation?" And they said to Pharaoh, "Your
servants are shepherds, as our fathers were." 4 They said to Pharaoh,
"We have come to sojourn in the land, for your servants' flocks have
no pasture, because the famine is heavy in the land of Canaan. Now,

please, let your servants live in the land of Goshen." 5 Pharaoh said to
Joseph, "Your father and your brothers have come to you here.[a] 6 The
land of Egypt is before you. Settle your father and your brothers in
the best of the land. Let them live in the land of Goshen, and if you
know any able men among them, put them in charge of my livestock."
7 Joseph brought his father Jacob in and presented him to Pharaoh,
and Jacob gave Pharaoh his blessing.[b] 8 And Pharaoh said to Jacob,
"How many are the days of the years of your life?" 9 And Jacob said to
Pharaoh, "The days of the years of my sojourning[c] are a hundred and
thirty years. Few and evil have been the days of the years of my life,
and they have not attained to the days of the years of the life of my
fathers in the days of their sojourning." 10 And Jacob blessed Pharaoh
and went out from the presence of Pharaoh. 11 Then Joseph settled
his father and his brothers and gave them a possession in the land
of Egypt, in the best of the land, in the land of Rameses,[d] as Pharaoh
had commanded. 12 Joseph supplied food to his father, his brothers,
and all his father's family, as much as each household needed for its
little ones.[e]
13 There was no food anywhere in the land, for the famine was
extremely severe, and the land of Egypt and the land of Canaan were
worn out because of the famine. 14 Joseph took in all the silver to be
found in Egypt and Canaan as payment for the grain people bought,
and he brought the silver to Pharaoh's palace. 15 When the silver of
Egypt and Canaan had run out, all Egypt came to Joseph and said,
"Give us bread! Must we die in front of you because we have no silver
left?" 16 "Then bring me your animals," Joseph said. "Since your silver
has run out, I will trade you food for your livestock." 17 They brought
their animals to Joseph, and he gave them food for their horses, sheep,
goats, cattle, and donkeys. Through that year he fed them in return
for all their herds. 18 When that year had passed, they came to him
the next year and said to him, "We cannot conceal from my lord that
our money is gone and the herds of cattle belong to my lord; nothing
remains before my lord except our bodies and our land. 19 Why should
we perish in front of you, we and our land as well? Take us and our
land in payment for bread. We and our fields will belong to Pharaoh.

Only give us seed, so that we may live and not die, and our land not be left barren." 20 So Joseph acquired all the farmland of Egypt for Pharaoh. Every Egyptian sold his field, because the famine pressed so hard on them, and the land came into Pharaoh's hands. 21 He moved the people to the cities,[f] from one end of the territory of Egypt to the other. 22 The priests' land was the only land he did not acquire. The priests received a set portion from Pharaoh and lived on what he allotted them, so they had no need to sell their land. 23 Joseph told the people, "Today I have acquired you and your land for Pharaoh. Here is seed for you. Plant the fields. 24 When the crops come in, a fifth part goes to Pharaoh. Four parts will be yours, as seed for the fields and as food for yourselves, your households, and your children." 25 "You have kept us alive," they said. "If it pleases my lord, we will be Pharaoh's servants." 26 Joseph made this a law for the land of Egypt, still in force today: a fifth belongs to Pharaoh. Only the priests' land never passed to Pharaoh.[g]

27 So Israel made his home in Egypt, in Goshen. They held land there, bore many children, and increased greatly. 28 And Jacob lived in the land of Egypt seventeen years. So the days of Jacob, the years of his life, were a hundred and forty-seven years. 29 As the time of Israel's death came near, he called for his son Joseph and said, "If you care for me, place your hand under my thigh[h] and swear to treat me with faithful love. Do not bury me in Egypt. 30 When I lie down with my fathers, carry me out of Egypt and bury me in their grave." Joseph replied, "I will do as you ask." 31 "Swear to me," he said, and Joseph swore to him. Then Israel bowed down at the head of the bed.[i]

Notes

- a (47:5) Brenton's Septuagint arranges 47:5–6 differently, with Pharaoh's reply to the brothers' request and his words to Joseph in another order.
- b (47:7) Or "greeted Pharaoh." The Hebrew verb barakh can mean a formal greeting or farewell (compare 47:10), but the narrative gives it the weight of the promise in 12:3.
- c (47:9) Or "my life as a foreigner," from the same root as ger, "foreigner" or "resident alien." Compare Hebrews 11:13.

- d (47:11) Rameses was a city of the eastern Nile Delta, named after the later kings called Ramesses (compare Exodus 1:11). The name may update an older place name for later readers.
- e (47:12) Literally "according to the mouth of the little ones."
- f (47:21) Or "he made slaves of them," as Brenton's Septuagint reads: "he brought the people into bondage to him, for servants." The Hebrew words for the two readings look alike, and the Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to agree with the Septuagint.
- g (47:26) Records from Egypt show land held by the crown and by the temples, and a tax on harvests, though the exact rate varied.
- h (47:29) A solemn form of oath; see the note on 24:2.
- i (47:31) Hebrew mittah, "bed." With different vowels the same letters read matteh, "staff." Brenton's Septuagint reads "Israel did reverence, leaning on the top of his staff," and Hebrews 11:21 quotes this form.

Chapter 48

1 Some time later Joseph was told, "Your father is sick." He took his
two sons Manasseh and Ephraim with him. 2 Someone told Jacob,
"Look, your son Joseph has come to see you." Israel summoned his
strength and sat up on the bed. 3 And Jacob said to Joseph, "El Shaddai[a]
appeared to me at Luz in the land of Canaan and blessed me, 4 and
said to me, 'I will make you fruitful and multiply you, and I will make
of you a company of peoples, and will give this land to your offspring
after you for an everlasting possession.' 5 Now your two sons, born
to you in the land of Egypt before I came to you in Egypt, are mine;
Ephraim and Manasseh will be mine, just as Reuben and Simeon are.
6 Any children born to you after them will be yours; in their inheri-
tance they will be named after their brothers.[b] 7 As for me, when I
was coming from Paddan, Rachel died beside me, to my sorrow, in
the land of Canaan on the road, while there was still some distance[c]
to go to Ephrath; I buried her there on the road to Ephrath (that is,
Bethlehem)."
8 Israel caught sight of Joseph's sons and asked, "Whose are these?"
9 Joseph said to his father, "They are my sons, whom God has given
me here." He said, "Bring them to me, I pray, and let me bless them." 10
Israel's eyes had grown dim with old age, so that he could hardly see.
Joseph brought the boys close to him, and he kissed them and held

them in his arms. 11 And Israel said to Joseph, "I never expected to see
your face; and now God has let me see your offspring also." 12 Then
Joseph brought them out from between his knees,[d] and he bowed
himself with his face to the earth. 13 And Joseph took them both,
Ephraim in his right hand toward Israel's left hand, and Manasseh in
his left hand toward Israel's right hand, and brought them near him. 14
But Israel reached out his right hand and placed it on Ephraim's head,
though he was the younger, and placed his left hand on Manasseh's
head. He crossed his hands on purpose,[e] although Manasseh was the
firstborn.
15 And he blessed Joseph and said, "The God before whom my fathers
Abraham and Isaac walked, the God who has been my shepherd[f] all
my life long to this day, 16 the angel who has rescued[g] me from every
harm, may he bless these boys. Through them may my name live on,
and the names of my fathers Abraham and Isaac. May they increase
into a great host upon the earth." 17 When Joseph noticed his father's
right hand resting on the younger boy, Ephraim, it troubled him. He
grasped his father's hand to move it over to Manasseh's head. 18 "No,
my father," Joseph said, "this is the firstborn. Place your right hand
on his head." 19 His father refused and said, "I am aware of it, my son, I
am aware. From him also a people will arise, and he also will be great;
yet his younger brother will be greater than he, and his offspring
will become a multitude[h] of nations." 20 He blessed them on that day
and said, "Israel will use your names in blessing, saying, 'May God
make you like Ephraim and Manasseh.'" So he set Ephraim ahead of
Manasseh.
21 Israel said to Joseph, "Look, I am dying, but God will be with you
and will bring you back to your fathers' land. 22 And to you, above
your brothers, I give one shoulder of land,[i] which I seized with sword
and bow from the hand of the Amorites."

Notes

- a (48:3) Traditionally "God Almighty"; see the note on El Shaddai at 17:1.
- b (48:6) Later children of Joseph are to be counted under Ephraim and Manasseh, not as tribes of their own.

- c (48:7) Literally “a stretch of land” (compare 35:16). Brenton’s Septuagint reads “as I drew nigh to the horse-course of Chabratha of the land of Chanaan.”
- d (48:12) That is, from Jacob’s knees, where they had been set as a sign that he received them as his own (compare 30:3; 50:23). Brenton’s Septuagint reads “they did reverence to him.”
- e (48:14) Or “acting wisely with his hands.” The Hebrew verb can mean “to cross” or “to act with understanding.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “guiding his hands crosswise.”
- f (48:15) Or “who has fed me.” Brenton’s Septuagint reads “the God who continues to feed me.”
- g (48:16) Hebrew go’el, the family member who rescues a relative, buys back land, or avenges blood. This is the first use of the word in the Bible.
- h (48:19) Literally “fullness.”
- i (48:22) Hebrew shekhem, “shoulder” or “ridge,” which is also the name of the city Shechem (compare 33:18–19; Joshua 24:32; John 4:5). Brenton’s Septuagint reads “I give to thee Sicima, a select portion above thy brethren.”

Chapter 49

1 Then Jacob called his sons and said, “Gather yourselves together,
that I may tell you what shall happen to you in the last days.[a] 2
Assemble and listen, O sons of Jacob, listen to Israel your father.
3 Reuben, you are my firstborn,[b] my might and the beginning of my
strength, excelling in dignity and excelling in power. 4 Unstable[c] as
water, you will not keep first place, for you climbed into your father’s
bed and defiled it. Onto my couch he climbed!
5 Simeon and Levi are brothers; weapons of violence are their swords.[d]
6 Into their council let my soul not enter; with their assembly, my
glory,[e] do not unite. For in their anger they slew men, and in their
willfulness they hamstrung oxen.[f] 7 Cursed be their anger, for it is
fierce, and their wrath, for it is cruel.[g] I will divide them in Jacob and
scatter them in Israel.
8 Judah, your brothers will praise you.[h] Your hand will grip your
enemies by the neck. Your father’s sons will bow low before you. 9
Judah is a lion’s cub; from the prey, my son, you have gone up.[i] He
crouched, he lay down like a lion, and like a lioness; who dares rouse
him? 10 The scepter will not leave Judah, nor the staff of command
from between his feet,[j] until Shiloh comes,[k] and the peoples will obey
him. 11 He ties his foal to the vine and his donkey’s colt to the choice

vine; he washes his garments in wine, his robe in the blood of grapes.
12 His eyes are darker than wine, and his teeth whiter than milk.[l]
13 Zebulun will live by the seashore. Ships will find shelter with him,
and his border will run toward Sidon.
14 Issachar is a sturdy donkey,[m] lying down among the saddlebags. 15
When he saw how good his resting place was, and how pleasant his
land, he lowered his shoulder to the load and became a laborer under
forced service.
16 Dan shall judge[n] his people as one of the tribes of Israel. 17 Dan shall
be a snake beside the road, a viper along the path, biting the horse's
heels so that its rider tumbles backward. 18 I wait for your salvation,
Yahweh.
19 Gad: raiders shall raid him, but he shall raid at their heels.[o]
20 Asher's bread will be rich, and he will provide food fit for a king.
21 Naphtali is a deer set free, who gives birth to beautiful fawns.[p]
22 Joseph is a fruitful bough, a fruitful bough by a spring; his branches
run over the wall.[q] 23 The archers savagely assailed him; they shot at
him and pressed him hard, 24 yet his bow remained steady; his arms
were made agile by the hands of the Mighty One of Jacob, from there,
the Shepherd, the Stone of Israel,[r] 25 by the God of your father, who
will help you, and by Shaddai,[s] who will bless you: blessings of the
heavens above, blessings of the abyss that lies below, blessings of the
breasts and of the womb. 26 Your father's blessings are greater than
the blessings of the age-old mountains, greater than the riches of the
lasting hills.[t] May they rest on Joseph's head, on the crown of the one
who was set apart[u] among his brothers.
27 Benjamin is a wolf that tears its prey. In the morning he eats what
he has caught, and in the evening he shares out the plunder."
28 These are all the twelve tribes of Israel, and this is what their father
spoke to them when he blessed them. He gave each one the blessing
that belonged to him. 29 Then he commanded them and said to them, "I
am to be gathered to my people; bury me with my fathers in the cave
that is in the field of Ephron the Hittite, 30 in the cave in the field of
Machpelah, facing Mamre in Canaan. Abraham bought it along with
the field from Ephron the Hittite as a burial site of his own. 31 There

they buried Abraham and Sarah his wife. There they buried Isaac and Rebekah his wife, and there I buried Leah, [32] the field and the cave that is in it, which were bought from the sons of Heth." [33] When Jacob had finished giving his sons their charge, he gathered his feet up onto the bed, breathed out his life, and was gathered to his people.

Notes

- a (49:1) Or "in days to come." Brenton's Septuagint reads "in the last days."
- b (49:3) Brenton notes that "thou my first-born" may also be read as an address, since the Greek does not always distinguish the two forms.
- c (49:4) Or "boiling over" or "reckless." Brenton's Septuagint reads "insolent like water." Reuben's act is told in 35:22.
- d (49:5) The Hebrew word translated "swords" is rare and uncertain. Brenton's Septuagint reads "accomplished the injustice of their cutting off." Compare chapter 34.
- e (49:6) Or "my heart" or "my soul," reading a Hebrew word with different vowels (compare Psalm 16:9).
- f (49:6) Literally "hamstrung an ox." Brenton's Septuagint reads "houghed a bull."
- g (49:7) Brenton notes that the Greek for "cruel" is more literally "hardened" or "aggravated." Levi was later scattered among the cities of Israel (Joshua 21), and Simeon's land lay within Judah (Joshua 19:1–9).
- h (49:8) A play on the name Judah, "praise" (compare 29:35).
- i (49:9) Brenton's Septuagint reads "from the tender plant, my son, thou art gone up."
- j (49:10) Brenton's Septuagint reads "nor a prince from his loins," and Brenton notes that the Greek reads "thighs."
- k (49:10) Or "until tribute comes to him," or "until he comes to whom it belongs," dividing or pointing the Hebrew letters differently. Shiloh was also the name of the town where the tabernacle later stood. Brenton's Septuagint reads "until there come the things stored up for him; and he is the expectation of nations." Many Jewish and Christian interpreters have read this verse as a promise of the Messiah.
- l (49:12) Or "Dark are his eyes from wine, and white his teeth from milk." Brenton's Septuagint reads "His eyes shall be more cheering than wine."
- m (49:14) Literally "a donkey of bone." Brenton's Septuagint reads "Issachar has desired that which is good; resting between the inheritances."
- n (49:16) A play on the name Dan, "judge" (compare 30:6).
- o (49:19) A play on the name Gad, which sounds like the Hebrew words for "raiders" and "raid."
- p (49:21) Or "who gives beautiful words." Brenton's Septuagint reads "Nephthalim is a spreading stem, bestowing beauty on its fruit."
- q (49:22) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult. Or "Joseph is a wild donkey's colt, a wild colt by a spring; wild donkeys on the ridge." "Fruitful" plays on the name

Ephraim (compare 41:52). Brenton's Septuagint reads "Joseph is a son increased; my dearly loved son is increased; my youngest son, turn to me."

- r (49:24) "The Mighty One of Jacob" is Hebrew abir ya'aqov, a title of God. The next words may also be read "from there is the Shepherd." Brenton's Septuagint reads "thence is he that strengthened Israel from the God of thy father."
- s (49:25) Shaddai, traditionally "the Almighty"; see the note on 17:1. Brenton's Septuagint reads "and my God helped thee."
- t (49:26) Or "mightier than the blessings of my forebears, to the bounds of the everlasting hills," reading the Hebrew words differently.
- u (49:26) Hebrew nazir, "one set apart" or "one consecrated," the word later used for a Nazirite (Numbers 6). Brenton's Septuagint reads "of whom he took the lead."

Chapter 50

1 Joseph threw himself on his father's face, weeping over him and
kissing him. 2 And Joseph commanded his servants the physicians
to embalm his father. So the physicians embalmed Israel. 3 The em-
balming took forty days, the full time it requires, and the Egyptians
mourned for Jacob seventy days.[a]
4 And when the days of weeping for him were past, Joseph spoke to
the household of Pharaoh, saying, "If now I have found favor in your
eyes, please speak in the ears of Pharaoh, saying, 5 'My father had me
take an oath. He said, "I am dying. Bury me in the grave I dug for
myself[b] in Canaan." So let me go up now and bury my father, and then
I will come back.'" 6 Pharaoh replied, "Go and bury your father, just as
you swore to him." 7 Joseph went up to bury his father, and with him
went up all of Pharaoh's servants, the elders of his house, and all the
elders of the land of Egypt, 8 Joseph's whole household went too, with
his brothers and his father's household. Only their little ones, their
sheep, and their cattle stayed behind in Goshen. 9 And there went up
with him both chariots and horsemen. It was a very great company.
10 They came to the threshing floor of Atad, across the Jordan, and
there they mourned with a very great and heavy lamentation; and
he observed seven days of mourning for his father. 11 The Canaanites
living there saw the mourning at the threshing floor of Atad and
said, "The Egyptians are mourning bitterly here." For this reason the
place, which lies across the Jordan, was named Abel-mizraim.[c] 12 So
Jacob's sons carried out his instructions. 13 They took him to Canaan

and buried him in the cave in the field of Machpelah, facing Mamre,
the cave Abraham had bought with the field from Ephron the Hittite
as a burial site of his own. 14 Once his father was buried, Joseph went
back to Egypt, together with his brothers and everyone who had gone
with him for the burial.
15 When Joseph's brothers saw that their father was dead, they said,
"What if Joseph hates us and pays us back in full for all the evil that
we did to him?" 16 They sent word to Joseph: "Before his death your
father gave us this instruction: 17 'This is what you shall say to Joseph:
"Please forgive[d] your brothers' transgression and their sin, for they
treated you badly." So now, please pardon the transgression of the
servants of the God of your father." Joseph wept while they spoke
to him. 18 Then his brothers came themselves and threw themselves
down in front of him. "We are your slaves," they said. 19 Joseph told
them, "Do not fear. Am I in God's place?[e] 20 As for you, you planned
evil against me, but God planned it for good, to bring about what is
happening today, the saving of many people alive.[f] 21 So now, do not
be afraid. I myself will sustain you and your little ones." He comforted
them and spoke to their hearts with kindness.
22 Joseph stayed in Egypt, he and his father's house, and Joseph lived
one hundred ten years.[g] 23 And Joseph saw Ephraim's children of the
third generation. The children also of Machir the son of Manasseh
were born upon Joseph's knees.[h] 24 Joseph told his brothers, "I am
dying, but God will surely visit you and bring you up from this land
to the land he promised by oath to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob."
25 Joseph had the sons of Israel swear an oath. "God will surely take
note of you," he said, "and then you must bring my bones up from
this place."[i] 26 So Joseph died, being a hundred and ten years old. They
embalmed him,[j] and he was put in a coffin in Egypt.

Notes

- a (50:3) Brenton's Septuagint reads "Egypt mourned for him seventy days." Egyptian sources also describe a long period of embalming and mourning, especially for persons of rank.
- b (50:5) Or "that I bought for myself." The Hebrew verb can mean either "dig" or "buy" (compare 23:16–20). Brenton's Septuagint reads "which I dug for myself."

- c (50:11) Abel-mizraim sounds like "mourning of Egypt" but means "meadow of Egypt." Brenton's Septuagint reads "The mourning of Egypt."
- d (50:17) Literally "lift up" or "bear." Brenton notes that the Greek is literally "accept."
- e (50:19) Brenton's Septuagint reads "Fear not, for I am God's."
- f (50:20) Brenton's Septuagint reads "that much people might be fed." Compare 45:5–8.
- g (50:22) A hundred and ten years was the Egyptian ideal of a full and blessed life. Joshua also dies at this age (Joshua 24:29).
- h (50:23) A sign that Joseph received them into his family (compare 30:3; 48:12). Brenton's Septuagint reads "were borne on the sides of Joseph," and Brenton notes that the Greek reads "thighs."
- i (50:25) Compare Exodus 13:19; Joshua 24:32; Hebrews 11:22.
- j (50:26) Brenton notes that the Greek reads "buried him" here, though his text reads "they prepared his corpse." Genesis ends with the hope of 50:24: God will visit his people and bring them to the promised land.

Exodus

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 These are the names[a] of the sons of Israel who came into Egypt with
Jacob; each man came with his household: 2 Reuben, Simeon, Levi,
and Judah, 3 Issachar, Zebulun, and Benjamin, 4 Dan and Naphtali,
Gad and Asher. 5 All the persons descended from Jacob[b] numbered
seventy.[c] Joseph was already in Egypt.
6 Then Joseph died, and all his brothers, and all that generation. 7 The
Israelites were fruitful and swarmed;[d] they became numerous and
grew exceedingly mighty, and the land was full of them.
8 Then a new king arose over Egypt who did not know Joseph. 9 He
said to his people, "See, the people of the Israelites are too many and
too mighty for us. 10 Come, let us deal shrewdly with them, or they
will multiply, and if war breaks out, they will join our enemies, fight
against us, and go up out of the land." 11 So they set taskmasters over
them to oppress them with forced labor. They built supply cities for
Pharaoh:[e] Pithom and Rameses.[f] 12 Yet the harder they were oppressed,
the more they increased and spread abroad, and the Egyptians grew
to dread the Israelites. 13 The Egyptians made the Israelites work ruthlessly. 14 They embittered their lives with harsh service, with mortar
and bricks and all manner of labor in the fields; in every task in which
they worked them, they were ruthless.
15 Then the king of Egypt spoke to the Hebrew midwives, one named
Shiphrah and the other named Puah.[g] 16 He said, "When you act as
midwife to the Hebrew women and look upon the birthstool,[h] if it
is a boy, you shall put him to death, but if it is a girl, she shall live."
17 The midwives, however, feared God. They did not do what the
king of Egypt had commanded them, and they kept the boys alive.
18 So the king of Egypt summoned the midwives and said to them,
"Why have you done this and let the boys live?" 19 The midwives

answered Pharaoh, “Hebrew women are not like Egyptian women; they are vigorous[i] and have given birth before the midwife arrives.” 20 So God dealt well with the midwives, and the people multiplied and grew very strong. 21 Because the midwives feared God, he gave them households of their own.[j] 22 Pharaoh then gave this command to all his people: “Every boy who is born[k] you shall cast into the Nile, but every girl you shall keep alive.”

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew we’elleh shemot, “and these are the names.” The opening words, Shemot (“Names”), are the Hebrew title of the book. The English title Exodus comes from the Greek Exodos, “departure.”
- b (1:5) Hebrew “who came out of Jacob’s thigh,” a Hebrew way of saying his direct descendants.
- c (1:5) The Septuagint and a Dead Sea Scroll of Exodus read “seventy-five,” the number Stephen gives in Acts 7:14. Genesis 46:27 gives seventy in the Hebrew and seventy-five in the Septuagint, which counts additional descendants of Joseph.
- d (1:7) Or “teemed.” The verbs echo the creation blessing of Genesis 1:28 and 9:1.
- e (1:11) Pharaoh is a title meaning “great house,” that is, the royal palace. Exodus never gives the personal name of the king.
- f (1:11) The Septuagint adds “and On, which is Heliopolis.”
- g (1:15) Shiphrah probably means “beautiful” and Puah perhaps “splendid” or “girl”; both meanings are uncertain. Both names are attested among Semitic names of the period. The Hebrew can also be read “the midwives of the Hebrews,” leaving open whether they were themselves Hebrews or Egyptians.
- h (1:16) Hebrew “on the two stones,” probably the stones a woman crouched on to give birth.
- i (1:19) Or “lively.” The Hebrew word occurs only here; it is related to the word for “living,” or perhaps to the word for “animal,” in the sense “they give birth easily, like animals.”
- j (1:21) Literally “he made houses for them,” that is, he gave them families.
- k (1:22) The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, and the Targums add “to the Hebrews.”

Chapter 2

1 Now a man from the house of Levi went and married a daughter of Levi.[a] 2 The woman conceived and bore a son. When she saw that he was a fine[b] child, she hid him three months. 3 When she was no longer able to hide him, she got a papyrus basket[c] for him and daubed it with bitumen and pitch. She placed the child in it and laid it among the

reeds at the edge of the Nile. 4 His sister stationed herself at a distance
to find out what would happen to him.
5 Then Pharaoh's daughter came down to bathe at the Nile, while
her young women walked along beside the Nile. She saw the basket
among the reeds and sent her servant girl to get it. 6 When she opened
it, she saw the child, and there was the boy, crying. She had pity on
him and said, "This is one of the Hebrews' children." 7 Then his sister
said to Pharaoh's daughter, "Shall I go and call a nursing woman from
the Hebrews to nurse the child for you?" 8 Pharaoh's daughter said to
her, "Go." So the young woman went and called the child's mother.
9 Pharaoh's daughter said to her, "Take this child away and nurse
him for me, and I will pay your wages." So the woman took the child
and nursed him. 10 The child grew, and she brought him to Pharaoh's
daughter, and he became a son to her. She called his name Moses,[d]
saying, "For I drew him out of the water."
11 In those days, when Moses had grown up, he went out to his
people[e] and looked at their forced labor. He saw an Egyptian beating
a Hebrew, one of his own people. 12 He looked this way and that, and
when he saw no one, he struck down the Egyptian and hid him in the
sand. 13 He went out the next day, and there were two Hebrew men
fighting. He said to the one in the wrong, "Why are you striking your
fellow Hebrew?" 14 But he said, "Who appointed you as prince and
judge over us? Do you intend to slay me, as you slew the Egyptian?"
Moses was frightened and thought, "Surely the matter has become
known." 15 When Pharaoh heard about this matter, he sought to
kill Moses. But Moses fled from Pharaoh and settled in the land of
Midian,[f] and he sat down by a well.
16 Now the priest of Midian had seven daughters. They came and drew
water and filled the troughs to water their father's flock. 17 Then the
shepherds came and drove them away, but Moses stood up, came
to their rescue, and watered their flock. 18 When they came to their
father Reuel,[g] he said, "Why have you come back so soon today?" 19
They said, "An Egyptian rescued us from the hand of the shepherds.
He even drew water for us and watered the flock." 20 He said to his
daughters, "Where is he, then? Why did you abandon the man? Call

him in to eat bread." 21 Moses agreed to stay with the man, and he gave Moses his daughter Zipporah[h] as wife. 22 She bore a son, and he named him Gershom,[i] for he said, "I have become a foreigner in a foreign land."[j]

23 In those many days[k] the king of Egypt died. The Israelites sighed because of their slavery and cried out; their plea for help from their bondage rose up to God. 24 God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob. 25 God saw the Israelites, and God knew.[l]

Notes

- a (2:1) The parents are named in 6:20 as Amram and Jochebed.
- b (2:2) Hebrew tov, "good," the word used in Genesis 1 when God saw that what he made was good.
- c (2:3) Hebrew tevah, the word used for Noah's ark (Genesis 6–9) and nowhere else in the Bible.
- d (2:10) The Hebrew name Mosheh sounds like mashah, "to draw out"; in form it means "one who draws out." It also resembles the Egyptian word mose, "is born" or "son," found in names such as Thutmose and Ahmose.
- e (2:11) Hebrew "his brothers," here and in the rest of the verse ("one of his brothers").
- f (2:15) Midian was a people of northwest Arabia and the Sinai region, descended from Abraham through Keturah (Genesis 25:2).
- g (2:18) Reuel means "friend of God." He is also called Jethro (3:1; 18:1) and, in Numbers 10:29, Moses' father-in-law is called "Hobab son of Reuel."
- h (2:21) Zipporah means "bird."
- i (2:22) Gershom sounds like ger sham, "a foreigner there."
- j (2:22) Some ancient witnesses, including some Septuagint manuscripts and the Latin Vulgate, add: "She conceived again and bore a son, and he named him Eliezer, saying, 'The God of my father is my help and has rescued me from the hand of Pharaoh.'" Compare 18:4.
- k (2:23) Hebrew "in those many days."
- l (2:25) Literally "and God knew," without an object. The Septuagint reads "and he made himself known to them." The sense is that God took notice of their condition.

Chapter 3

1 Moses was tending the flock of his father-in-law Jethro,[a] the priest of Midian. He led the flock to the far side of the wilderness and came to Horeb,[b] the mountain of God. 2 The angel of Yahweh[c] appeared to him in a flame of fire from the middle of a bush.[d] He looked, and there was

the bush, burning with fire, yet the bush was not consumed. 3 Moses said, "I must turn aside and see this great sight, why the bush does not burn up." 4 Yahweh saw that he turned aside to see, and God called to him out of the midst of the bush: "Moses, Moses!" And he answered, "Here I am." 5 Then he said, "Come no closer. Remove your sandals from your feet, for the place on which you stand is holy ground." 6 He also said, "I am the God of your father,[e] the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob." Moses hid his face, for he was afraid to look at God.

7 Then Yahweh said, "I have surely seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt. I have heard their cry because of their taskmasters. I know their sufferings. 8 So I have come down to deliver them from the power of the Egyptians and to bring them up from that land into a good and broad land, a land flowing with milk and honey,[f] to the place of the Canaanites and the Hittites and the Amorites and the Perizzites and the Hivites and the Jebusites.[g] 9 Behold, the outcry of the Israelites has reached me, and I myself have seen the oppression with which the Egyptians are oppressing them. 10 So now go. I am sending you to Pharaoh, so that you may bring my people, the Israelites, out of Egypt."

11 But Moses said to God, "Who am I, that I should go to Pharaoh and bring the Israelites out of Egypt?" 12 He said, "I will be with you.[h] And this will be the sign for you that I have sent you: when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you will worship God on this mountain."

13 Then Moses said to God, "Suppose I come to the Israelites and say to them, 'The God of your fathers has sent me to you,' and they ask me, 'What is his name?' What shall I tell them?" 14 God said to Moses, "I am who I am."[i] And he said, "This is what you are to say to the Israelites: 'I am[j] has sent me to you.'" 15 God also said to Moses, "This is what you are to say to the Israelites: 'Yahweh,[k] the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, has sent me to you.' This is my name forever, and this is how I am to be remembered from generation to generation.[l]

16 “Go and assemble the elders of Israel and say to them, ‘Yahweh,
the God of your fathers—the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—has
appeared to me and said, “I have surely taken note of you[m] and of
what is being done to you in Egypt. 17 I have promised to bring you up
from the affliction of Egypt into the land of the Canaanites and the
Hittites and the Amorites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites
—a land that flows with milk and honey.”’ 18 They will heed your voice.
Then you and the elders of Israel shall go in to the king of Egypt and
say to him, ‘Yahweh, the God of the Hebrews, has encountered us;
now, we ask, let us go a three days’ journey into the wilderness, that
we may sacrifice to Yahweh our God.’ 19 But I know that the king of
Egypt will not let you go unless he is forced by a mighty hand.[n] 20
So I will stretch out my hand and strike Egypt with all my wonders
that I will do among them. After that he will let you go. 21 And I will
give this people favor in the sight of the Egyptians, so that when
you go, you will not go empty-handed. 22 Each woman shall ask her
neighbor, and any woman who lodges in her house, for silver articles
and gold articles and for garments; you shall put these on your sons
and daughters, and so you shall strip the Egyptians.”

Notes

- a (3:1) Jethro probably means “abundance” or “excellence.” He is called Reuel in 2:18.
- b (3:1) Horeb, meaning “dry” or “desolate,” is another name for Mount Sinai.
- c (3:2) Yahweh is the personal name of God, written in Hebrew with the four letters YHWH. This is its first appearance in Exodus; on its meaning, see the note at 3:15. Here “the angel of Yahweh” is soon identified with Yahweh himself (verse 4).
- d (3:2) Hebrew seneh, a thorny bush, probably a kind of bramble or acacia. The word sounds like Sinai.
- e (3:6) The Samaritan Pentateuch and some Septuagint manuscripts read “fathers,” as in verses 13 and 15.
- f (3:8) A traditional description of a fertile land good for grazing (milk from goats and sheep) and for bees or fruit (honey can also mean syrup made from dates or figs).
- g (3:8) The list of the peoples of Canaan varies in length and order; the Septuagint and the Samaritan Pentateuch often add the Girgashites to make seven peoples, as in Deuteronomy 7:1.
- h (3:12) Hebrew ki ehyeh immak, “for I will be with you.” The verb ehyeh (“I will be”) prepares for the name God gives in verse 14.

- i (3:14) Hebrew ehyeh asher ehyeh. The verb hayah, “to be,” in this form can mean “I am,” “I will be,” or “I become,” so the phrase can also be translated “I will be who I will be” or “I am the one who is.” The Septuagint translates “I am the one who exists” (ego eimi ho on). The name expresses God’s self-existence, his faithful presence with his people (verse 12), and his freedom to make himself known as he chooses.
- j (3:14) Hebrew ehyeh, “I am” or “I will be,” the first word of verse 14 used as a name. The Septuagint reads “The one who is has sent me.”
- k (3:15) Hebrew YHWH, God’s personal name, which occurs about 6,800 times in the Hebrew Bible. Here God explains it by the verb in verse 14: ehyeh (“I am”) is the name in God’s own mouth, and YHWH (“he is” or “he will be”) is the same name spoken by others about him. Ancient Hebrew was written without vowels, and from the centuries before Christ onward, Jews out of reverence stopped pronouncing the name and read Adonai, “Lord,” in its place. The Septuagint translated it kyrios, “Lord,” and most English Bibles print “the LORD.” The pronunciation Yahweh is supported by early Christian writers who give it in Greek as Iaoue and Iabe, and by the short form Yah (15:2) and names such as Elijah and Isaiah. The form “Jehovah” arose later by combining the consonants YHWH with the vowels of Adonai. This translation writes the name as Yahweh throughout.
- l (3:15) Literally “and this is my remembrance from generation to generation.”
- m (3:16) Or “I have surely visited you,” that is, come to your aid. Joseph used the same words in Genesis 50:24–25.
- n (3:19) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint reads “except by a mighty hand,” and some interpreters read the Hebrew “not even by a mighty hand,” meaning that only the plagues will break his resistance.

Chapter 4

1 Moses answered, “But what if they will not believe me or listen to
my voice, and say, ‘Yahweh did not appear to you’?” 2 Yahweh said to
him, “What is that in your hand?” He said, “A staff.” 3 He said, “Throw
it on the ground.” So he threw it on the ground, and it became a snake,
and Moses ran from it. 4 Yahweh said to Moses, “Stretch out your hand
and seize it by the tail.” He stretched out his hand and took hold of
it, and it turned into a staff in his palm. 5 “This is so that they may
believe that Yahweh, the God of their fathers, the God of Abraham,
the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, has appeared to you.”
6 Yahweh also said to him, “Put your hand inside your cloak.” So he
put his hand inside his cloak, and when he took it out, there was his
hand, diseased,[a] white as snow. 7 He said, “Return your hand to your

bosom." So he returned his hand to his bosom, and when he brought it out of his bosom, it was restored like the rest of his flesh. 8 "If they will not believe you or listen to the voice of the first sign, they may believe the voice of the second sign. 9 And if they will not believe even these two signs or listen to your voice, take some water from the Nile and pour it on the dry ground. The water you take from the Nile will become blood on the dry ground."

10 But Moses said to Yahweh, "Please, Lord,[b] I have never been eloquent, neither yesterday nor the day before, nor since you began to speak to your servant; for I am slow in speaking and slow in tongue." 11 Yahweh said to him, "Who put a mouth on humankind?[c] Or who makes someone mute or deaf, sighted or blind? Is it not I, Yahweh? 12 So now go, and I will be with your mouth and teach you what you are to say." 13 But he said, "Please, Lord, send someone else, anyone you will send."[d] 14 Yahweh's anger flared against Moses. He said, "Is not Aaron[e] the Levite your brother? I know that he speaks well. Now see, he is on his way out to meet you, and when he sees you he will rejoice in his heart. 15 You will speak to him and put the words in his mouth. I will be with your mouth and with his mouth, and I will teach you both what you are to do. 16 He will speak for you to the people. He will be a mouth for you, and you will be like God to him.[f] 17 And take this staff in your hand, with which you will do the signs."

18 Moses departed and returned to Jether,[g] his father-in-law, and said to him, "Let me go, I pray, and return to my kinsmen who are in Egypt, and see whether they are still living." Jethro said to Moses, "Go in peace." 19 Yahweh said to Moses in Midian, "Go, return to Egypt, for all the men who were seeking your life are dead." 20 Moses took his wife and his sons, set them upon a donkey, and returned to the land of Egypt; and the staff of God was in his hand.

21 Yahweh said to Moses, "As you go back to Egypt, take care to do before Pharaoh all the wonders that I have placed in your hand. But I will harden[h] his heart, so that he will not release the people. 22 Then you are to say to Pharaoh, 'This is what Yahweh says: Israel is my son, my firstborn. 23 I said to you, "Let my son go, so that he may serve

me." But you refused to let him go. So now I will kill your son, your firstborn.'"

24 On the way, at a lodging place, Yahweh met him[i] and sought to put
him to death. 25 Then Zipporah took a flint knife and cut her son's
foreskin, and she touched it to his feet[j] and said, "You are indeed a
bridegroom of blood to me!" 26 So he let him go. She had said "bride-
groom of blood" on account of the circumcision.[k]

27 Yahweh said to Aaron, "Go into the wilderness to meet Moses." So
he went and met him at the mountain of God and kissed him. 28 Moses
told Aaron all the words of Yahweh with which he had sent him,
and all the signs he had commanded him to do. 29 Then Moses and
Aaron went and gathered all the elders of the Israelites. 30 Aaron told
them all the words that Yahweh had spoken to Moses, and he did the
signs before the eyes of the people. 31 The people believed; and when
they heard that Yahweh had visited the Israelites and had seen their
affliction, they bowed their heads and worshiped.

Notes

- a (4:6) Hebrew metsora'at, traditionally "leprous." The Hebrew term covers a range of skin diseases and is not limited to leprosy (Hansen's disease).
- b (4:10) Hebrew Adonai, "Lord," a title of respect, not the divine name. So also in verse 13.
- c (4:11) Hebrew adam, "humankind" or "a human being."
- d (4:13) Literally "send by the hand of whom you will send."
- e (4:14) The meaning of the name Aaron is uncertain; it may be of Egyptian origin.
- f (4:16) Hebrew "you will be God to him." Moses will give Aaron the message as God gives a message to a prophet. Compare 7:1.
- g (4:18) Jether is a short form of Jethro; the Samaritan Pentateuch and several Hebrew manuscripts read "Jethro" here.
- h (4:21) Hebrew hazaq, "to make strong" or "make firm." Exodus uses three verbs for Pharaoh's hardened heart: hazaq ("make strong," as here), kaved ("make heavy," first in 7:14), and qashah ("make hard," first in 7:3). Sometimes God is the subject, sometimes Pharaoh hardens his own heart, and sometimes the text simply says that his heart was hardened.
- i (4:24) Hebrew "met him." The Hebrew does not say whether "him" is Moses or his son. The Septuagint reads "an angel of the Lord met him."
- j (4:25) Hebrew "his feet," perhaps a polite way of referring to the genitals. Whose feet are meant, those of Moses, of the son, or of the one who attacked, is not stated.

- k (4:26) Or "because of the circumcision." The meaning of this very brief and ancient story is uncertain. Zipporah's act seems to supply a missing circumcision and so to turn away the threat.

Chapter 5

1 Afterward Moses and Aaron went in and spoke to Pharaoh: "Thus
says Yahweh, the God of Israel: 'Send my people away, that they may
celebrate a feast to me in the wilderness.'" 2 Pharaoh answered, "Who
is Yahweh, that I should obey his voice and send Israel away? I do not
know Yahweh, and I certainly will not send Israel away." 3 They said,
"The God of the Hebrews has encountered us. Let us go, we pray, a
journey of three days into the wilderness and sacrifice to Yahweh our
God, lest he strike us with pestilence or with the sword." 4 The king of
Egypt said to them, "Moses and Aaron, why do you draw the people
away from their work? Go back to your burdens!" 5 Pharaoh also said,
"Look, the people of the land are now many,[a] and you would make
them rest from their labors!"
6 On that very day Pharaoh gave orders to the taskmasters over the
people and to their foremen,[b] 7 "You shall no longer supply the people
with straw for making bricks, as in the past; let them go and collect
straw for themselves. 8 But you are to require of them the same quota
of bricks they made before. Do not reduce it, for they are lazy. That
is why they are crying out, 'Let us go and sacrifice to our God.' 9 Let
heavier work be laid on the men, so that they are kept busy with it
and pay no attention to lying words."
10 The people's taskmasters and their foremen went out and spoke to
the people: "Thus says Pharaoh: 'I am not giving you straw. 11 You
yourselves go and take straw wherever you can find it, but none of
your work will be diminished.'" 12 So the people scattered throughout
the land of Egypt to gather stubble for straw. 13 The taskmasters kept
pressing them, saying, "Finish your work, your daily quota, just as
when there was straw." 14 And the foremen of the Israelites, whom
Pharaoh's taskmasters had set over them, were beaten and asked,
"Why have you not completed your quota of bricks yesterday and
today, as before?"

15 Then the foremen of the Israelites came and cried out to Pharaoh,
"Why do you treat your servants this way? 16 No straw is given to your
servants, yet they say to us, 'Make bricks!' Look, your servants are
beaten, but the fault is with your own people."[c] 17 He answered, "You
are idle, you are idle! That is why you keep saying, 'Let us go and
sacrifice to Yahweh.' 18 Now go and work. No straw will be given to
you, but you must still deliver the full quota of bricks." 19 The foremen
of the Israelites saw that they were in trouble when they were told,
"You must not reduce your daily quota of bricks."
20 As they left Pharaoh's presence, they encountered Moses and Aaron
standing in their path to meet them. 21 They said to them, "May
Yahweh look upon you and judge you, for you have made our scent
foul in the eyes of Pharaoh and of his servants, putting a sword in
their hands to kill us."
22 Then Moses turned to Yahweh and said, "Lord,[d] why have you
brought trouble on this people? Why did you ever send me? 23 From
the time I came to Pharaoh to speak in your name, he has dealt badly
with this people, and you have not delivered your people at all."

Notes

- a (5:5) The Samaritan Pentateuch reads "now they are more numerous than the people of the land."
- b (5:6) Hebrew shoterim, officials or scribes, here Israelites appointed over their own people (verse 14).
- c (5:16) The Hebrew is difficult, literally "and your people sin." The Septuagint reads "you wrong your people."
- d (5:22) Hebrew Adonai.

Chapter 6

1 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Now you will see what I will do to
Pharaoh. Under a mighty hand he will let them go; under a mighty
hand he will drive them out of his land."
2 God spoke to Moses and said to him, "I am Yahweh. 3 I appeared
to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob as El Shaddai,[a] but I was not known
to them by my name Yahweh.[b] 4 I also established my covenant with
them, to give them the land of Canaan, the land where they lived
as foreigners. 5 Moreover, I have heard the groaning of the Israelites,

whom the Egyptians are holding in slavery, and I have remembered my covenant. 6 Therefore say to the Israelites, 'I am Yahweh, and I will bring you out from beneath the forced labor of the Egyptians; I will free you from their servitude, and I will redeem[c] you with an outstretched arm and with mighty acts of judgment. 7 I will take you as my people, and I will be your God. Then you will know that I am Yahweh your God, who brought you out from under the burdens of the Egyptians. 8 I will lead you into the land that I swore[d] to give to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and I will give it to you for a possession. I am Yahweh.'" 9 Moses spoke thus to the Israelites, but they did not heed him on account of their anguish of spirit[e] and their hard bondage.

10 Then Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 11 "Go in, tell Pharaoh king of Egypt to let the Israelites go out of his land." 12 Moses spoke before Yahweh, saying, "See, the Israelites have not heeded me; how then will Pharaoh heed me, since my lips are uncircumcised?"[f] 13 Yet Yahweh spoke to Moses and Aaron and gave them a charge concerning the Israelites and Pharaoh king of Egypt, to bring the Israelites out of the land of Egypt.

14 These are the heads of their fathers' houses. The sons of Reuben, the firstborn of Israel: Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi. These are the clans of Reuben. 15 The sons of Simeon: Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar, and Shaul, the son of a Canaanite woman. These are the clans of Simeon. 16 These are the names of Levi's sons, by their generations: Gershon,[g] Kohath, and Merari. Levi's lifetime was 137 years. 17 The sons of Gershon: Libni and Shimei, by their clans. 18 The sons of Kohath: Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel. Kohath's lifetime was 133 years. 19 The sons of Merari: Mahli and Mushi. These are the clans of the Levites according to their generations. 20 Amram took Jochebed,[h] his father's sister,[i] as his wife, and she bore him Aaron and Moses.[j] Amram's lifetime was 137 years.[k] 21 The sons of Izhar: Korah, Nepheg, and Zichri. 22 The sons of Uzziel: Mishael, Elzaphan, and Sithri. 23 Aaron married Elisheba,[l] daughter of Amminadab and sister of Nahshon, and she bore him Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar,[m] and Ithamar. 24 The sons of Korah: Assir, Elkanah, and Abiasaph. These

are the clans of the Korahites. 25 Eleazar, Aaron's son, married one of the daughters of Putiel, and she bore him Phinehas.[n] These are the heads of the fathers' houses of the Levites by their clans.
26 These are the same Aaron and Moses to whom Yahweh said, "Bring the Israelites out of the land of Egypt by their divisions."[o] 27 It was these who spoke to Pharaoh, king of Egypt, in order to bring the Israelites out of Egypt—this Moses and this Aaron.
28 On the day when Yahweh spoke to Moses in the land of Egypt, 29 Yahweh said to Moses, "I am Yahweh. Tell Pharaoh king of Egypt everything that I tell you." 30 But Moses said before Yahweh, "Look, I have uncircumcised lips. How then will Pharaoh listen to me?"

Notes

- a (6:3) El Shaddai is traditionally translated "God Almighty," following the Septuagint of some books and the Latin Vulgate (omnipotens). Its original meaning is uncertain; suggestions include "God of the mountain," "God of the fields," and "God who is sufficient." It is the name by which God made himself known to Abraham in Genesis 17:1. The Septuagint here reads "being their God."
- b (6:3) Or as a question, "did I not make myself known to them?" The name Yahweh appears often in Genesis, so the point is probably that the patriarchs did not yet know God in the full sense of this name, as the one who keeps his promises by acts of deliverance.
- c (6:6) Hebrew ga'al, to act as a kinsman-redeemer, a relative who buys back a family member from slavery or restores lost family property.
- d (6:8) Literally "I lifted my hand," a gesture of swearing an oath.
- e (6:9) Hebrew "shortness of spirit," that is, discouragement or impatience.
- f (6:12) That is, lips unfit for speaking, as a closed or unready organ. Compare 4:10.
- g (6:16) Gershon (or Gershom) probably sounds like garash, "drive out." He is a different person from Moses' son Gershom (2:22).
- h (6:20) Jochebed probably means "Yahweh is glory"; it is the first personal name in the Bible built on the name Yahweh.
- i (6:20) Hebrew dodah, "father's sister" or "aunt." The Septuagint and the Vulgate read "his father's brother's daughter," that is, his cousin, perhaps to avoid a marriage later forbidden in Leviticus 18:12.
- j (6:20) The Samaritan Pentateuch and the Septuagint add "and Miriam their sister."
- k (6:20) The Septuagint (Vaticanus) reads 132 years, and Codex Alexandrinus 136.
- l (6:23) Elisheba means "my God is fullness" or "my God has sworn." The same name appears in the New Testament as Elizabeth.
- m (6:23) Eleazar means "God has helped."
- n (6:25) Phinehas is an Egyptian name meaning "the Nubian."

- o (6:26) Hebrew tsava'ot, "armies" or "hosts," the same word as in the title "Yahweh of Armies." Israel leaves Egypt organized like an army.

Chapter 7

1 Yahweh said to Moses, "See, I have made you like God[a] to Pharaoh,
and your brother Aaron will be your prophet. 2 You are to speak
everything I command you, and your brother Aaron is to tell Pharaoh
to let the Israelites go out of his land. 3 I will harden[b] Pharaoh's heart,
and I will make my signs and my wonders many in the land of Egypt.
4 Pharaoh will not listen to you. Then I will lay my hand on Egypt
and bring my divisions, my people the Israelites, out of the land of
Egypt with great acts of judgment. 5 The Egyptians will know that I
am Yahweh when I stretch out my hand against Egypt and bring the
Israelites out from among them." 6 Moses and Aaron did so; just as
Yahweh commanded them, so they did. 7 Moses was eighty years old
and Aaron eighty-three years old when they spoke to Pharaoh.
8 Yahweh said to Moses and Aaron, 9 "When Pharaoh says to you,
'Perform a wonder,' then say to Aaron, 'Take your staff and throw it
down before Pharaoh,' and it will become a serpent."[c] 10 So Moses and
Aaron went in to Pharaoh and did just as Yahweh had commanded.
Aaron threw down his staff before Pharaoh and his servants, and it
became a serpent. 11 Pharaoh, for his part, summoned the wise men
and the sorcerers, and the magicians[d] of Egypt did likewise with their
enchantments. 12 Each one threw down his staff, and they became
serpents. But Aaron's staff swallowed up their staffs. 13 Yet Pharaoh's
heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, just as Yahweh
had said.
14 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Pharaoh's heart is stubborn;[e] he
refuses to let the people go. 15 Go to Pharaoh in the morning, when he
goes out to the water. Station yourself at the edge of the Nile to meet
him, and take in your hand the staff that was changed into a snake. 16
Tell him, 'Yahweh, the God of the Hebrews, has sent me to you with
this message: "Send my people away, that they may serve me in the
wilderness." And see, until now you have not obeyed. 17 This is what
Yahweh says: "By this you will know that I am Yahweh: I will strike

the water in the Nile with the staff that is in my hand, and it will turn into blood. 18 The fish in the Nile will die, the river will stink, and the Egyptians will not be able to drink from the Nile's water.'"'[f] 19 Yahweh said to Moses, "Say to Aaron, 'Take your staff and stretch out your hand over the waters of Egypt, over their rivers, their canals, their ponds, and all their pools of water, so that they become blood.' There will be blood throughout the land of Egypt, even in vessels of wood and of stone." 20 Moses and Aaron did so, as Yahweh had commanded. Lifting up the staff, he struck the waters of the Nile before the eyes of Pharaoh and of his servants, and all the waters of the river were changed to blood. 21 The fish that were in the river died, and the river stank, and the Egyptians could not drink the Nile's water; and there was blood in every part of the land of Egypt. 22 But the magicians of Egypt did the same by their secret arts. So Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, just as Yahweh had said. 23 Pharaoh turned and went back to his house, and did not lay even this to heart. 24 All the Egyptians dug around the Nile for water to drink, because they could not drink the water of the Nile. 25 Seven full days passed after Yahweh had struck the Nile.

Notes

- a (7:1) Hebrew elohim, "God" or "a god." Moses will speak with divine authority before Pharaoh, and Aaron will speak for him as a prophet speaks for God (compare 4:16).
- b (7:3) Hebrew qashah, "make hard" or "make stubborn." See the note at 4:21.
- c (7:9) Hebrew tannin, a different word from the "snake" (nahash) of 4:3. It can mean a large serpent or a sea creature such as a crocodile.
- d (7:11) Hebrew hartummim, a word borrowed from Egyptian, meaning priests skilled in sacred writings and magic. Jewish tradition gives the names of two of them as Jannes and Jambres (2 Timothy 3:8).
- e (7:14) Hebrew kaved, "heavy." See the note at 4:21. In Egyptian belief the heart of the dead was weighed against a feather, and a heavy heart was a guilty one.
- f (7:18) Throughout the plague accounts (chapters 7–11), the Samaritan Pentateuch adds passages that repeat God's commands in full as Moses and Aaron carry them out, or that report Moses' words to Pharaoh before each plague. Similar expansions appear in a Dead Sea Scroll of Exodus written in the old Hebrew script. This translation follows the shorter Masoretic Text.

Chapter 8

1 Then Yahweh said to Moses,[a] "Go in to Pharaoh and say to him,
'This is what Yahweh says: "Let my people go, so that they may serve
me. 2 If you refuse to let them go, I will strike your whole territory
with frogs. 3 The Nile will swarm with frogs. They will come up into
your house, into your bedroom and onto your bed, into the houses of
your servants and onto your people, into your ovens and into your
kneading bowls. 4 The frogs will come up on you, on your people, and
on all your servants."'"
5 Yahweh said to Moses, "Say to Aaron: 'Reach out your hand with
the staff above the streams, the canals, and the pools, so that frogs
come up upon Egypt's land.'" 6 So Aaron stretched out his hand over
the waters of Egypt, and the frogs[b] came up and covered the land
of Egypt. 7 The magicians did likewise with their enchantments and
brought up frogs upon the land of Egypt.
8 Then Pharaoh called Moses and Aaron and said, "Pray to Yahweh
to take the frogs away from me and from my people, and I will let
the people go to sacrifice to Yahweh." 9 Moses said to Pharaoh, "You
may have the honor over me:[c] for when shall I pray for you, for your
servants, and for your people, that the frogs be removed from you
and your houses and remain only in the Nile?" 10 He said, "Tomorrow."
Moses said, "It will be as you say, so that you may know that there is
no one like Yahweh our God. 11 The frogs will go away from you and
your houses, your servants and your people; only in the Nile will they
be left." 12 Then Moses and Aaron went out from Pharaoh, and Moses
cried out to Yahweh about the frogs he had brought on Pharaoh. 13
Yahweh did according to Moses' word, and the frogs died out of the
houses, the courtyards, and the fields. 14 They piled them up in heaps,
and the land stank. 15 But when Pharaoh saw that there was relief, he
made his heart stubborn and did not listen to them, just as Yahweh
had said.
16 Yahweh said to Moses, "Tell Aaron, 'Extend your staff and hit the
dust of the earth, that it may turn into gnats[d] in every part of the land
of Egypt.'" 17 They did so: Aaron held out his hand with his staff and
hit the dust of the earth, and gnats came upon man and beast. All

the dust of the earth turned into gnats in the whole land of Egypt.
18 The magicians tried with their enchantments to bring forth gnats,
but they were unable; and the gnats remained on man and beast. 19
Then the magicians said to Pharaoh, "This is the finger of God." But
Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, just as
Yahweh had said.
20 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Rise early in the morning and stand
before Pharaoh as he goes out to the water. Say to him, 'This is what
Yahweh says: "Let my people go, so that they may serve me. 21 If you
will not let my people go, I will send swarms of flies[e] on you, on
your servants, on your people, and into your houses. The houses of
the Egyptians will be full of swarms of flies, and so will the ground
they stand on. 22 On that day I will make a distinction regarding the
land of Goshen, where my people dwell, so there will be no swarm
of flies there, that you may know that I, Yahweh, am in the midst of
the land.[f] 23 I will put a division[g] between my people and your people.
This sign will happen tomorrow."'" 24 Yahweh did so. Thick swarms
of flies entered Pharaoh's house and the houses of his servants, and
in all the land of Egypt the country was devastated by the flies.
25 Then Pharaoh called Moses and Aaron and said, "Go, sacrifice to
your God within the land." 26 But Moses said, "It would not be right to
do so, for the sacrifices we offer to Yahweh our God are detestable to
the Egyptians. If we offer sacrifices detestable to the Egyptians before
their eyes, will they not stone us? 27 We must go a three days' journey
into the wilderness and sacrifice to Yahweh our God, as he tells us."
28 Pharaoh said, "I will release you, and you may sacrifice to Yahweh
your God in the wilderness; only do not go very far. Make entreaty
for me." 29 Moses said, "As soon as I go out from you, I will pray to
Yahweh, and tomorrow the swarms of flies will depart from Pharaoh,
from his servants, and from his people. Only let Pharaoh not deal
falsely again by not letting the people go to sacrifice to Yahweh." 30 So
Moses went out from Pharaoh and prayed to Yahweh. 31 Yahweh did as
Moses asked and removed the swarms of flies from Pharaoh, from his
servants, and from his people; not one remained. 32 But Pharaoh made
his heart stubborn this time also, and he did not let the people go.

Notes

- a (8:1) Verses 8:1–4 are numbered 7:26–29 in the Hebrew text, and verses 8:5–32 are numbered 8:1–28.
- b (8:6) Hebrew "the frog," used as a collective.
- c (8:9) Literally "glorify yourself over me," a courteous way of letting Pharaoh set the time.
- d (8:16) Or "lice." The exact insect is uncertain; the Septuagint reads "gnats" (skniphes).
- e (8:21) Hebrew arov, "swarm" or "mixture." The Septuagint takes it as "dog-flies." Some Jewish interpreters understood it as a mixture of wild animals.
- f (8:22) Or "I, Yahweh, am in the midst of the land."
- g (8:23) So the Septuagint and the Latin Vulgate. The Hebrew reads pedut, "redemption," which may be a copying error for pelut, "separation," or may mean "I will set redemption between my people and your people."

Chapter 9

1 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Go in to Pharaoh and tell him, 'This
is what Yahweh, the God of the Hebrews, says: "Let my people go, so
that they may serve me. 2 For if you refuse to let them go and still hold
on to them, 3 the hand of Yahweh will fall with a very heavy pestilence
upon your livestock in the field: upon the horses, the donkeys, the
camels, the cattle, and the sheep. 4 Yahweh will separate the livestock
of Israel from the livestock of Egypt, and nothing belonging to the
Israelites will die."'" 5 Yahweh set a time, saying, "Tomorrow Yahweh
will do this thing in the land." 6 On the next day Yahweh did this. All
the livestock of Egypt died,[a] yet of the Israelites' livestock not a single
one died. 7 Pharaoh sent men, and they found that not even one of
Israel's livestock was dead. Yet Pharaoh's heart remained stubborn,
and he did not release the people.
8 Yahweh said to Moses and Aaron, "Fill your hands with soot from a
furnace, and let Moses toss it toward the sky before Pharaoh's eyes. 9
It will become fine dust over all the land of Egypt and will cause boils
breaking out in sores on people and animals throughout all the land
of Egypt." 10 They took soot from the furnace and stood in Pharaoh's
presence; Moses tossed it toward the sky, and it became festering
boils breaking out on man and beast. 11 The magicians could not stand
before Moses because of the boils, for the boils were on the magicians

and on all the Egyptians. 12 But Yahweh hardened Pharaoh's heart,
and he did not listen to them, just as Yahweh had told Moses.
13 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Rise early in the morning, stand before
Pharaoh, and tell him, 'This is what Yahweh, the God of the Hebrews,
says: "Let my people go, so that they may serve me. 14 For this time I
will send all my plagues upon your heart,[b] upon your servants, and
upon your people, so that you may know that there is no one like me
in all the earth. 15 For by now I could have put out my hand and smitten
you and your people with pestilence, and you would have been cut
off from the earth. 16 Yet for this very reason I have kept you standing:[c]
to show you my power, and that my name may be proclaimed in all
the earth. 17 You still exalt yourself against my people and will not let
them go. 18 Tomorrow about this time I will rain down a very heavy
hail, the like of which has not been in Egypt since the day it was
founded until now. 19 Now therefore send and bring your livestock
and all that you have in the field to safety. Every person and animal
that is found in the field and not brought home will die when the hail
comes down on them."'" 20 Pharaoh's servants who feared the word
of Yahweh gathered their servants and livestock into houses. 21 But
whoever did not take the word of Yahweh to heart left his servants
and his livestock in the field.
22 Yahweh said to Moses, "Raise your hand toward the heavens, that
hail may fall on the entire land of Egypt—upon man and beast and
every plant of the field in the land of Egypt." 23 Moses stretched out
his staff toward the sky, and Yahweh sent thunder[d] and hail, and fire
came down to the earth. Yahweh rained hail on the land of Egypt. 24
The hail fell, and fire flared up amid the hail—hail so very heavy that
the like of it had not been seen in the whole land of Egypt since it
became a nation. 25 Throughout the land of Egypt the hail beat down
all that was in the open country, man and beast alike; it also beat
down every plant of the field and broke every tree in the field. 26 Only
in the land of Goshen, where the Israelites were, was there no hail.
27 Pharaoh sent for Moses and Aaron and said to them, "I have sinned
this time; Yahweh is righteous, and I and my people are wicked. 28
Pray to Yahweh, for there has been enough of God's thunder[e] and

hail. I will let you go; you need stay no longer." 29 Moses said to him, "As soon as I have gone out of the city, I will spread out my hands to Yahweh. The thunder will stop, and there will be no more hail, so that you may know that the earth belongs to Yahweh. 30 But as for you and your servants, I know that you do not yet fear Yahweh God."[f] 31 (The barley and the flax were destroyed, because the barley had come into ear while the flax was budding. 32 But the wheat and the spelt[g] were not struck down, for they ripen later.) 33 So Moses went out of the city from Pharaoh and spread out his hands to Yahweh. The thunder and the hail stopped, and the rain no longer poured on the earth. 34 When Pharaoh saw that the rain and the hail and the thunder had ceased, he sinned again, making his heart stubborn—he and his servants. 35 So Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not let the Israelites go, just as Yahweh had said through Moses.

Notes

- a (9:6) That is, all the livestock in the field (verse 3). Livestock are again mentioned in 9:19–21 and 9:25, probably animals that had been sheltered or acquired since.
- b (9:14) Or "against you yourself." The Hebrew "upon your heart" may refer to the plagues' effect on Pharaoh's will.
- c (9:16) Or "I have kept you alive" or "I have raised you up." Paul quotes this verse in Romans 9:17.
- d (9:23) Hebrew "voices," a common way of describing thunder. So also in verses 28, 29, 33, and 34.
- e (9:28) Hebrew "voices of God," or "mighty thunder."
- f (9:30) The full title "Yahweh God," so frequent in Genesis 2–3, is rare elsewhere in the Pentateuch. The Septuagint reads "the Lord."
- g (9:32) Or "emmer," an ancient variety of wheat.

Chapter 10

1 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Go in to Pharaoh, for I have made his heart and the hearts of his servants stubborn, so that I may show these signs of mine among them, 2 and that you may tell your son and your grandson how severely I dealt with the Egyptians, and the signs that I performed among them, so that you will know that I am Yahweh."

3 So Moses and Aaron went in to Pharaoh and said to him, "This is what Yahweh, the God of the Hebrews, says: 'How long will you

refuse to humble yourself before me? Let my people go, so that they may serve me. 4 For if you refuse to let my people go, tomorrow I will bring locusts into your territory. 5 They will cover the face of the land, so that no one can see the land. They will eat what is left to you after the hail, and they will eat every tree of yours that grows in the field. 6 They will fill your houses, and the houses of all your servants, and the houses of all the Egyptians, as neither your fathers nor your grandfathers have ever seen since they were on the earth, down to this day.'" Then he turned and left Pharaoh's presence.
7 Pharaoh's servants said to him, "How long will this fellow be a trap for us? Release the men, that they may serve Yahweh their God. Have you not yet realized that Egypt is destroyed?" 8 So Moses and Aaron were brought back to Pharaoh, and he said to them, "Go, serve Yahweh your God. But who exactly is going?" 9 Moses said, "We will go with our young and our old; with our sons and our daughters, with our sheep and our cattle we will go, for we have a festival of Yahweh."
10 He said to them, "May Yahweh be with you if I ever let you go with your little ones![a] Look, you clearly have evil in mind. 11 No! Go, you men, and serve Yahweh, for that is what you want." And they were thrown out of Pharaoh's presence.
12 Yahweh said to Moses, "Hold out your hand over the land of Egypt for the locusts, that they may come up over the land of Egypt and devour all the plants of the land, everything the hail has left." 13 So Moses stretched out his staff over the land of Egypt, and Yahweh drove an east wind over the land all that day and all that night. When it was morning, the east wind had brought the locusts. 14 The locusts came up over all the land of Egypt and settled on the whole territory of Egypt in very great numbers. Never before had there been such a swarm of locusts, nor will there ever be again. 15 They covered the surface of the whole land, so that the land was darkened. They ate every plant of the land and all the fruit of the trees that the hail had left. Nothing green remained, neither tree nor plant of the field, in all the land of Egypt.
16 Then Pharaoh hurriedly called Moses and Aaron and said, "I have sinned against Yahweh your God and against you. 17 So now, please

pardon my sin this once only, and entreat Yahweh your God to take this death away from me." 18 So he went out from Pharaoh and prayed to Yahweh. 19 Yahweh shifted the wind to an extremely strong west wind,[b] which lifted up the locusts and blew them into the Red Sea.[c] Not one locust remained anywhere within Egypt's territory. 20 But Yahweh hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he did not let the Israelites go. 21 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward the sky, so that there may be darkness over the land of Egypt, a darkness that can be felt." 22 So Moses stretched out his hand toward the sky, and there was thick darkness in all the land of Egypt for three days. 23 One could not see another, and for three days no one got up from where he was; but all the Israelites had light in their dwellings. 24 Then Pharaoh called Moses and said, "Go, serve Yahweh. Only let your flocks and your herds stay behind. Even your little ones may go with you." 25 Moses said, "You yourself must also supply[d] us with sacrifices and burnt offerings, that we may offer them to Yahweh our God. 26 Our livestock too will go with us; we will leave not even a hoof behind, since we must choose some of them for the service of Yahweh our God, and we cannot know what we shall use to serve Yahweh until we get there." 27 But Yahweh hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he was not willing to let them go. 28 Pharaoh said to him, "Get out of my sight! Take care not to appear before me again; for on the day you see my face you will die." 29 Moses replied, "You have spoken rightly. I will never see your face again."

Notes

- a (10:10) Pharaoh's words are sarcastic: "May Yahweh be with you just as surely as I will let you go with your little ones."
- b (10:19) Hebrew "a sea wind," that is, a wind from the Mediterranean Sea, to the west of Egypt.
- c (10:19) Hebrew yam suf, literally "Sea of Reeds." The Septuagint calls it the "Red Sea," and the name is used in the Bible both for the Gulf of Suez and the Gulf of Aqaba, arms of the Red Sea, and perhaps for marshy lakes near the Isthmus of Suez. The exact place of Israel's crossing (chapter 14) is uncertain.
- d (10:25) Hebrew "give into our hand."

Chapter 11

1 Yahweh said to Moses, "I will bring one more plague on Pharaoh and
on Egypt; afterward he will send you away from here. When he sends
you away, he will drive you out altogether. 2 Tell the people, please,
that each man is to ask of his neighbor and each woman of hers for
silver articles and gold articles." 3 Yahweh gave the people favor in the
sight of the Egyptians. Moreover, the man Moses was very great in
the land of Egypt, in the sight of Pharaoh's servants and in the sight
of the people.
4 Moses said, "This is what Yahweh says: 'About midnight I will go
out through the midst of Egypt. 5 Every firstborn in the land of Egypt
shall perish, from the firstborn of Pharaoh sitting on his throne to
the firstborn of the slave girl at the millstones, and all the firstborn of
the cattle. 6 There will be a great cry throughout all the land of Egypt,
such as there has never been and never will be again. 7 But among all
the Israelites no dog will so much as growl,[a] whether at man or beast,
so that you may know that Yahweh distinguishes between Egypt and
Israel.' 8 All these servants of yours will come down to me and bow
down to me, saying, 'Go out, you and all the people who follow you.'
After that I will go out." And he went out from Pharaoh in hot anger.
9 Yahweh had said to Moses, "Pharaoh will not listen to you, so that
my wonders may be multiplied in the land of Egypt." 10 Moses and
Aaron did all these wonders before Pharaoh, but Yahweh hardened
Pharaoh's heart, and he did not let the Israelites go out of his land.

Notes

- a (11:7) Hebrew "not a dog will sharpen its tongue."

Chapter 12

1 Yahweh said to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, 2 "This month
shall be the head of months for you; it is the first of the months of the
year for you, in March–April.[a] 3 Tell the whole congregation of Israel:
On the tenth day of this month (in March–April) each man is to take
a lamb[b] for his family, a lamb for each household. 4 If a household
is too small for a whole lamb, then he and the neighbor next to his
house shall share one, in proportion to the number of persons; you

shall apportion the lamb according to what each can eat. 5 Your lamb
must be without defect, a male a year old. You may take it from the
sheep or from the goats. 6 You are to keep it until the fourteenth
day of this month (in March–April). Then the whole assembly of the
congregation of Israel is to slaughter it at twilight.[c] 7 They are to take
some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of
the houses in which they eat it. 8 They are to eat the meat that same
night, roasted over the fire. They are to eat it with unleavened bread[d]
and bitter herbs. 9 Do not eat any of it raw or boiled in water, but
roasted over the fire, its head with its legs and its inner parts. 10 Do not
leave any of it until morning. Whatever remains of it until morning
you are to burn with fire. 11 In this way you shall eat it: your loins
girded, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand; and
you shall eat it hurriedly. It is Yahweh's Passover.[e] 12 For on that night
I will pass through the land of Egypt and strike down every firstborn
in the land of Egypt, both people and animals, and on all the gods of
Egypt I will execute judgments. I am Yahweh. 13 The blood will be a
sign for you on the houses where you are. When I see the blood, I
will pass over you, and no plague will come upon you to destroy you
when I strike the land of Egypt.
14 "This day shall be a remembrance for you, and you shall celebrate it
as a feast to Yahweh. Throughout your generations you shall observe
it as an everlasting statute. 15 Seven days you shall eat unleavened
bread; on the very first day you shall clear out leaven from your
houses, for anyone who eats leavened bread from the first day
through the seventh, that person shall be cut off from Israel. 16 On the
first day there shall be a holy convocation for you, and on the seventh
day another holy convocation. No work shall be done in them, except
what every person needs to eat; that alone may be prepared by you.
17 You shall keep the Feast of Unleavened Bread, for on this very day
I brought your hosts out of the land of Egypt. So you shall keep this
day in all your generations, as an everlasting ordinance. 18 In the first
month (March–April),[f] on the fourteenth day of the month, in the
evening, you shall eat unleavened bread, until the twenty-first day of
the month in the evening. 19 Seven days long no leaven may be found

in your houses; for anyone who eats what is leavened, that person shall be cut off from the community of Israel, whether a sojourner or one born in the land. 20 You are not to eat anything leavened. In all your dwellings you are to eat unleavened bread."
21 Then Moses called all the elders of Israel and said to them, "Go, select lambs for yourselves according to your families, and slaughter the Passover lamb. 22 You shall take a bunch of hyssop,[g] dip it in the blood in the basin,[h] and strike the lintel and the two doorposts with the blood from the basin; and none of you shall go out through the door of his house until morning. 23 For Yahweh will pass through to strike the Egyptians. When he sees the blood on the lintel and on the two doorposts, Yahweh will pass over the door and will not allow the destroyer to enter your houses to strike you. 24 You are to observe this as a statute for you and for your children forever. 25 When you come to the land that Yahweh will give you, as he has promised, you are to keep this service. 26 And when your children ask you, 'What does this service mean to you?' 27 you shall say, 'It is the sacrifice of Yahweh's Passover, for he passed over the homes of the Israelites in Egypt when he struck down the Egyptians but delivered our households.'" Then the people bowed their heads and worshiped. 28 The Israelites departed and did it; as Yahweh had commanded Moses and Aaron, so they did.
29 At midnight Yahweh struck down every firstborn in the land of Egypt, from the firstborn of Pharaoh who sat on his throne to the firstborn of the captive who was in the dungeon,[i] and all the firstborn of the livestock. 30 Pharaoh rose up in the night, he and all his servants and all the Egyptians, and there was a great cry in Egypt, for there was not a house where someone was not dead. 31 Then he called Moses and Aaron by night and said, "Rise up, go out from among my people, both you and the Israelites. Go, serve Yahweh, as you have said. 32 Take your flocks and your herds, as you have said, and go. And bless me also."
33 The Egyptians urged the people to hurry and send them out of the land, for they said, "We will all be dead." 34 So the people took their dough before it was leavened, with their kneading bowls bound up

in their cloaks on their shoulders. 35 The Israelites had done as Moses
said; they had asked the Egyptians for articles of silver and articles
of gold, and for clothing. 36 Yahweh had given the people favor in the
sight of the Egyptians, so that they gave them what they asked. So
they plundered the Egyptians.
37 The Israelites set out from Rameses to Succoth,[j] about 600,000 men
on foot,[k] besides children. 38 A mixed multitude[l] went up with them
as well, along with flocks and herds, and a very large number of
livestock. 39 From the dough that they had brought out of Egypt they
baked cakes of unleavened bread, for it had not risen; they had been
expelled from Egypt and were unable to delay, and they had made no
provisions for themselves.
40 The time that the Israelites lived in Egypt[m] was 430 years. 41 And
it came about at the end of 430 years, on that very day, that all the
hosts of Yahweh went out from the land of Egypt. 42 It was a night
of watching by Yahweh, to bring them out of the land of Egypt. This
same night is a night of watching for Yahweh by all the Israelites
throughout their generations.
43 Yahweh said to Moses and Aaron, "This is the statute of the
Passover: no foreigner is to eat of it. 44 But any man's slave who has
been bought for money may eat of it after you have circumcised him.
45 No temporary resident or hired worker may eat of it. 46 It must be
eaten within one house; none of the flesh may be taken outside the
house, and you must not break any bone of it.[n] 47 The whole congre-
gation of Israel is to keep it. 48 If a foreigner living among you wants
to keep the Passover to Yahweh, all his males must be circumcised,
and then he may come near and keep it. He will be like a native of
the land. But no uncircumcised person may eat of it. 49 There is to be
one law for the native and for the foreigner who lives among you." 50
All the Israelites did so; just as Yahweh had commanded Moses and
Aaron, so they did. 51 On that very day Yahweh brought the Israelites
out of the land of Egypt by their divisions.

Notes

- a (12:2) Hebrew "the first month." This month, called Abib in the early sources (13:4) and later Nisan, begins the spring-start religious calendar. Because the

Hebrew months were lunar, each overlaps two of our months, and the exact dates varied from year to year; the first month fell in March–April. The dates in verses 3, 6, and 18 are in this month.

- b (12:3) Hebrew seh, a young animal of the flock, either a lamb or a young goat (verse 5).
- c (12:6) Hebrew "between the two evenings," understood either as between sunset and dark or as between midafternoon and sunset.
- d (12:8) Hebrew matsot, flat bread made without yeast or leaven.
- e (12:11) Hebrew pesah. The name is explained in verses 13, 23, and 27 by the verb pasah, "to pass over," or perhaps "to protect, hover over."
- f (12:18) Hebrew "In the first month." See the note at verse 2.
- g (12:22) Hyssop is probably the plant now called Syrian marjoram (Origanum syriacum), whose hairy branches hold liquid well.
- h (12:22) Or "on the threshold." The Hebrew word saf can mean either.
- i (12:29) Hebrew "the house of the pit."
- j (12:37) Rameses was the store city of 1:11, in the eastern Nile Delta. Succoth, meaning "booths," is probably Egyptian Tjeku, in the Wadi Tumilat.
- k (12:37) The Hebrew word elef, "thousand," may in some lists mean a clan or military unit, so the number of people intended is debated.
- l (12:38) Hebrew erev rav, people of other nations who joined Israel.
- m (12:40) The Samaritan Pentateuch reads "in the land of Canaan and in the land of Egypt," and the Septuagint reads "in the land of Egypt and in the land of Canaan." Those readings count the 430 years from Abraham's entry into Canaan, as Paul does in Galatians 3:17. Compare Genesis 15:13, which gives a round 400 years for the oppression.
- n (12:46) John 19:36 applies this to Jesus.

Chapter 13

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Set apart for me every firstborn;
whatever first opens the womb among the Israelites, of man and of
beast, belongs to me."
3 Moses said to the people, "Remember this day on which you came
out from Egypt, out of the house of slavery, for by strength of hand
Yahweh brought you out from this place. No leavened bread is to be
eaten. 4 Today, in the month of Abib (March–April),[a] you are going
out. 5 When Yahweh brings you into the land of the Canaanites, the
Hittites, the Amorites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites, which he swore
to your fathers to give you, a land flowing with milk and honey, you
are to keep this service in this month. 6 For seven days you are to

eat unleavened bread, and on the seventh day there is to be a festival to Yahweh. 7 Unleavened bread is to be eaten for the seven days. No leavened bread is to be seen with you, and no leaven is to be seen with you in all your territory. 8 You shall tell your son on that day, 'This is on account of what Yahweh did for me when I came out of Egypt.' 9 It shall be for you as a sign upon your hand and as a memorial between your eyes,[b] that the law of Yahweh may be on your lips; for Yahweh brought you out of Egypt with a mighty hand. 10 You are to keep this statute at its appointed time from year to year.
11 "When Yahweh brings you into the land of the Canaanites, as he swore to you and to your fathers, and gives it to you, 12 you are to set apart to Yahweh all that first opens the womb. Every firstborn male of your livestock belongs to Yahweh. 13 Every firstborn donkey you shall redeem with a lamb; if you will not redeem it, then you shall break its neck. And every firstborn of your sons you shall redeem. 14 When your son asks you later, 'What is this?' you shall answer him, 'By the strength of his hand Yahweh brought us out from Egypt, from the house of slavery. 15 For when Pharaoh was obstinate about sending us away, Yahweh slew every firstborn in the land of Egypt, from the firstborn of man to the firstborn of beast. Therefore I sacrifice to Yahweh all the males that open the womb, but every firstborn of my sons I redeem.' 16 It will be a sign on your hand and a symbol[c] between your eyes, for by strength of hand Yahweh brought us out of Egypt."
17 When Pharaoh let the people go, God did not lead them by the road to the land of the Philistines, although that was nearer. For God said, "The people may change their minds when they see war, and return to Egypt." 18 God took the people around by the wilderness road to the Red Sea; the Israelites left the land of Egypt armed for battle.[d] 19 Moses took the bones of Joseph with him, for Joseph had made the Israelites solemnly swear, saying, "God will surely take note of you, and then you must carry my bones up from here with you."[e] 20 They set out from Succoth and camped at Etham, on the edge of the wilderness. 21 Yahweh was going before them in the daytime in a pillar of cloud to guide them on the road, and at night in a pillar of fire to give them light, so that they might travel day and night. 22 He did not remove

the pillar of cloud by day, nor the pillar of fire by night, from its place before the people.

Notes

- a (13:4) Abib means "ears of grain," the month of the barley harvest. It was the first month of the spring-start religious calendar (12:2), falling in March–April, and was later called Nisan.
- b (13:9) That is, on the forehead. Later Jewish practice fulfilled this literally with tefillin (phylacteries), small boxes containing passages of the law.
- c (13:16) Hebrew totafot, a band or emblem worn on the forehead.
- d (13:18) Hebrew hamushim, perhaps "arranged in ranks" or "in groups of fifty." The Septuagint reads "in the fifth generation."
- e (13:19) Genesis 50:25.

Chapter 14

1 Then Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Tell the Israelites to turn back and camp in front of Pi-hahiroth,[a] between Migdol and the sea, in front of Baal-zephon. You are to camp facing it, by the sea. 3 Pharaoh will say of the Israelites, 'They are wandering aimlessly in the land; the wilderness has shut them in.' 4 Then I will harden Pharaoh's heart, so that he pursues them; I will get glory[b] for myself over Pharaoh and over all his forces, and the Egyptians shall know that I am Yahweh." So they did.

5 When the king of Egypt was told that the people had fled, the hearts of Pharaoh and his servants were changed toward the people, and they said, "What is this we have done, that we have let Israel go from serving us?" 6 So he harnessed his chariot and took his army with him. 7 He took six hundred select chariots and all the other chariots of Egypt, with officers[c] over all of them. 8 Yahweh hardened the heart of Pharaoh king of Egypt, and he pursued the Israelites, while the Israelites were going out boldly.[d] 9 The Egyptians pursued them—every horse and chariot of Pharaoh, his cavalry, and his troops—and caught up with them camped at the sea, beside Pi-hahiroth, opposite Baal-zephon.

10 When Pharaoh came near, the Israelites lifted their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians were advancing after them; and they were greatly afraid, and the Israelites cried out to Yahweh. 11 They said to Moses,

"Is it because Egypt had no graves that you have taken us to die in the wilderness? Why have you treated us this way by bringing us out of Egypt? 12 Did we not say this to you in Egypt: 'Let us be, so that we may serve the Egyptians'? For serving the Egyptians would have been better for us than dying in the wilderness." 13 Moses said to the people, "Do not be afraid. Stand firm and see the salvation of Yahweh, which he will accomplish for you today. For the Egyptians you see today you will never see again. 14 Yahweh will do battle for you, and you need only be silent."

15 Yahweh said to Moses, "Why do you cry out to me? Tell the Israelites to go forward. 16 Lift up your staff, and hold out your hand over the sea and split it, so that the Israelites can walk into the midst of the sea on dry land. 17 And I will harden the hearts of the Egyptians so that they will go in after them, and I will gain glory over Pharaoh and all his army, his chariots, and his horsemen. 18 The Egyptians will know that I am Yahweh when I have gained glory over Pharaoh, his chariots, and his horsemen."

19 The angel of God, who went ahead of the camp of Israel, moved away and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud left its place in front and stood behind them, 20 and it came between the Egyptian camp and the camp of Israel. The cloud was there with the darkness, yet it lit the night;[e] so neither came near the other all night long.

21 Then Moses stretched out his hand over the sea, and Yahweh drove the sea back by a strong east wind all night and made the sea dry land, and the waters were divided. 22 The Israelites went into the middle of the sea on dry ground, with the waters forming a wall for them on their right and on their left. 23 The Egyptians pursued and went in after them into the middle of the sea, all Pharaoh's horses, his chariots, and his horsemen. 24 Between about two and six in the morning,[f] Yahweh gazed down from the pillar of fire and cloud upon the army of the Egyptians and threw them into a panic. 25 He took off the wheels of their chariots,[g] so that they drove them with difficulty. The Egyptians said, "Let us run away from Israel, for Yahweh is fighting on their behalf against Egypt."

26 Then Yahweh told Moses, “Reach your hand out over the sea, that
the waters may return upon the Egyptians, on their chariots and on
their horsemen.” 27 So Moses stretched out his hand over the sea, and
at daybreak the sea returned to its normal flow. As the Egyptians fled
before it, Yahweh shook off the Egyptians into the middle of the sea.
28 The waters flowed back and covered the chariots and the horsemen
of all Pharaoh’s forces that had gone in after them into the sea; not
a single one of them was left. 29 As for the Israelites, they went on
dry land in the middle of the sea, and the waters were a wall to them
on the right and on the left. 30 So Yahweh saved Israel that day from
the hand of the Egyptians, and Israel saw the Egyptians dead on the
seashore. 31 Israel saw the great power[h] that Yahweh used against
the Egyptians, and the people feared Yahweh, and they believed in
Yahweh and in his servant Moses.

Notes

- a (14:2) Pi-hahiroth may be Egyptian for “house of Hathor” or Hebrew for “mouth of the canals.” Migdol means “tower” or “fortress,” and Baal-zephon means “lord of the north,” the name of a Canaanite god given to a place. None of these sites has been identified with certainty.
- b (14:4) Or “glorify myself,” “show my glory.” So also in verses 17 and 18.
- c (14:7) Hebrew shalishim, perhaps “third men,” the third man in a chariot, or more generally high-ranking officers.
- d (14:8) Hebrew “with a high hand,” that is, openly and defiantly.
- e (14:20) The Hebrew is difficult. It may mean that the cloud brought darkness to the Egyptians and light to Israel. The Septuagint reads “and there was darkness and blackness, and the night passed.”
- f (14:24) Hebrew “In the morning watch,” the last of the three watches into which the night was divided, from about 2 a.m. until about 6 a.m.
- g (14:25) So the Hebrew, literally “he turned aside the wheels.” The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, and the Syriac read “he bound” or “clogged,” a difference of one letter.
- h (14:31) Hebrew “the great hand.”

Chapter 15

1 Then Moses and the Israelites sang this song to Yahweh, and said: “I
will sing to Yahweh, for he is highly exalted;[a] horse and its rider[b] he
has thrown into the sea. 2 Yah[c] is my strength and my song,[d] and he
has become my salvation. This is my God, and I will praise him, my

father's God, and I will exalt him. 3 Yahweh is a warrior; Yahweh is
his name. 4 Pharaoh's chariots and his forces he hurled into the sea;
the pick of his officers were sunk in the Red Sea. 5 The deeps cover
them; they went down into the depths like a stone. 6 Your right hand,
Yahweh, glorious in power, your right hand, Yahweh, shatters the
enemy. 7 By the abundance of your majesty you throw down those
who rise up against you; you let loose your wrath, and it devours
them like stubble. 8 By the breath of your nostrils the waters were
heaped together; the floods stood upright like a mound; the depths
were frozen in the midst of the sea. 9 The enemy said, 'I will pursue, I
will overtake, I will divide the plunder; my desire will have its fill of
them. I will draw my sword; my hand will destroy them.' 10 You blew
with your breath; the sea covered them. They sank like lead in the
mighty waters. 11 Who among the gods is like you, Yahweh? Who is
like you, glorious in holiness, fearful in praises, working wonders?
12 You stretched out your right hand; the earth swallowed them. 13 In
your loyal love[e] you led the people you redeemed; you guided them in
your strength to your holy abode. 14 Nations have heard and shudder;
pangs have taken hold of those who live in Philistia. 15 Now the chiefs
of Edom are terrified; trembling grips the leaders[f] of Moab; all who
live in Canaan have melted away. 16 Fear and dread fall upon them;
by the might of your arm they are motionless as stone, until your
people cross over, Yahweh, until the people you have acquired go
across.[g] 17 You will bring them in and plant them on the mountain of
your inheritance, the place, Yahweh, which you have made for your
dwelling, the sanctuary, Lord,[h] which your hands have established. 18
Yahweh will reign forever and ever."
19 For when Pharaoh's horses with his chariots and his horsemen went
into the sea, Yahweh brought back the waters of the sea upon them,
but the Israelites walked on dry ground in the middle of the sea. 20
Then Miriam[i] the prophetess, Aaron's sister, took a tambourine in
her hand, and all the women went out after her with tambourines
and with dancing. 21 Miriam sang to them: "Sing to Yahweh, for he is
highly exalted; horse and its rider he has thrown into the sea."

22 Then Moses had Israel depart from the Red Sea, and they went into
the wilderness of Shur;[j] they traveled three days in the wilderness and
found no water. 23 They arrived at Marah but could not drink the water
there, because it was bitter; therefore its name was called Marah.[k] 24
The people grumbled against Moses, saying, "What are we to drink?"
25 Moses cried to Yahweh, and Yahweh showed him a piece of wood.[l]
He cast it into the water, and the water became sweet. There Yahweh[m]
established for them a statute and an ordinance, and there he tested
them. 26 He said, "If you will diligently obey the voice of Yahweh your
God, doing what is right in his eyes, giving ear to his commandments,
and keeping all his statutes, I will lay on you none of the sicknesses
that I laid on the Egyptians; for I am Yahweh, your healer."[n]
27 Then they came to Elim,[o] where there were twelve springs of water
and seventy palm trees, and they camped there by the water.

Notes

- a (15:1) Literally "for he has risen up proudly," or "gloriously triumphed." The Hebrew repeats the verb for emphasis.
- b (15:1) Or "its chariot driver."
- c (15:2) Yah is a short form of Yahweh, appearing first here. It is familiar from the word hallelujah, "praise Yah."
- d (15:2) Or "my might." Verse 2a is repeated in Isaiah 12:2 and Psalm 118:14.
- e (15:13) Hebrew hesed, the faithful, steadfast love that belongs to a covenant relationship.
- f (15:15) Hebrew "rams," a figure for chiefs or strong men.
- g (15:16) Or "created."
- h (15:17) Hebrew Adonai. Many Hebrew manuscripts and the Samaritan Pentateuch read "Yahweh."
- i (15:20) The meaning of the name Miriam is uncertain; suggestions include "bitter," "beloved" (from Egyptian), and "rebellious." The Greek form of the name is Mariam, the name Mary in the New Testament.
- j (15:22) Shur means "wall," perhaps named after a line of Egyptian border fortifications.
- k (15:23) Marah means "bitter."
- l (15:25) Or "a tree."
- m (15:25) Hebrew "he."
- n (15:26) Hebrew Yahweh rofe'ekha. Some later writers turned this phrase into the compound name "Yahweh Rophe," "Yahweh who heals."
- o (15:27) Elim means "large trees" or "terebinths."

Chapter 16

1 They set out from Elim, and the whole congregation of the Israelites
came to the wilderness of Sin,[a] which is between Elim and Sinai,
on the fifteenth day of the second month (in April–May)[b] after they
had come out of the land of Egypt. 2 The whole congregation of the
Israelites grumbled against Moses and Aaron in the wilderness. 3 The
Israelites said to them, "Would that we had died by Yahweh's hand in
the land of Egypt, where we sat by the pots of meat and ate bread to
the full! For you have led us out into this wilderness to let this entire
assembly die of hunger."
4 Yahweh said to Moses, "See, I will soon rain bread from heaven for
you; the people shall go out and gather each day's portion on its day,
that I may test them to see whether they will walk in my law or not.
5 On the sixth day, when they prepare what they bring in, it will be
twice as much as they gather on other days." 6 Moses and Aaron told
all the Israelites, "In the evening you will know that it is Yahweh who
brought you out of the land of Egypt, 7 and in the morning you will see
the glory of Yahweh, because he has heard your grumbling against
Yahweh. For what are we, that you grumble against us?" 8 Moses said,
"Yahweh will give you meat to eat in the evening and in the morning
bread to the full, because Yahweh has heard your grumbling that you
make against him. Who are we? Your grumbling is not against us but
against Yahweh."
9 Then Moses said to Aaron, "Say to the whole congregation of the
Israelites, 'Come near before Yahweh, for he has heard your grum-
bling.'" 10 While Aaron was speaking to the whole community of the
Israelites, they turned toward the wilderness, and behold, the glory
of Yahweh appeared in the cloud. 11 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 12
"I have heard the grumbling of the Israelites. Speak to them and say,
'At twilight[c] you will eat meat, and in the morning you will be filled
with bread. Then you will know that I am Yahweh your God.'"
13 In the evening quail came up and covered the camp, and in the
morning there was a layer of dew around the camp. 14 When the layer
of dew had gone up, there on the surface of the wilderness was some-
thing fine and flaky, fine as frost on the ground. 15 When the Israelites

saw it, they said to one another, "What is it?"[d] For they did not know what it was. Moses said to them, "It is the bread that Yahweh has given you to eat. 16 This is what Yahweh has commanded: 'Each of you is to gather as much of it as he can eat. You are to take about 2 quarts[e] for each person, according to the number of persons; each of you is to take it for those in his tent.'" 17 The Israelites did so. They gathered, some more and some less. 18 But when they measured it out,[f] whoever had gathered much had nothing left over, and whoever had gathered little had no lack. Each had gathered as much as he could eat. 19 Moses said to them, "No one is to leave any of it until morning." 20 But they did not listen to Moses. Some of them left part of it until morning, and it bred worms and stank. And Moses was angry with them. 21 They gathered it every morning, each according to what he needed to eat; and when the sun grew hot, it melted away.

22 On the sixth day they gathered twice as much bread, about 4 quarts[g] for each person. When all the leaders of the congregation came and told Moses, 23 he said to them, "This is what Yahweh commanded: 'Tomorrow is a Sabbath of complete rest, a holy Sabbath[h] to Yahweh. What you will bake, bake; and what you will boil, boil; and all the remainder lay up for yourselves to keep until morning.'" 24 They laid it up until morning, as Moses had ordered; and it did not smell foul, and no worm was in it. 25 Moses said, "Eat it today, for today is a Sabbath to Yahweh. Today you will not find it in the field. 26 For six days you shall gather it, but on the seventh day, which is the Sabbath, there will be none."

27 On the seventh day some of the people went out to gather, but they found none. 28 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "How long will you refuse to keep my commandments and my laws? 29 See, Yahweh has given you the Sabbath; that is why on the sixth day he gives you bread for two days. Each of you is to stay where he is; no one is to go out of his place on the seventh day." 30 So the people rested on the seventh day.

31 The house of Israel named it manna.[i] It was like coriander seed, white, and its taste was like wafers made with honey. 32 Moses said, "This is what Yahweh has commanded: 'Let about 2 quarts[j] of it be kept throughout your generations, so that they may see the bread

with which I fed you in the wilderness when I brought you out of the land of Egypt.'" 33 Moses told Aaron, "Take one jar and put in it about 2 quarts of manna, and set it before Yahweh to be preserved for your generations." 34 As Yahweh commanded Moses, so Aaron placed it before the testimony,[k] to be kept. 35 The Israelites ate the manna forty years, until they came to an inhabited land. They ate the manna until they came to the border of the land of Canaan. 36 (The daily measure of about 2 quarts was one tenth of the standard dry measure of about three-fifths of a bushel.)[l]

Notes

- a (16:1) Sin here is a place name, unrelated to the English word "sin." It is probably related to the name Sinai.
- b (16:1) Hebrew "on the fifteenth day of the second month," counting from the spring new year (see the note at 12:2). The second month, later called Iyyar (Ziv in 1 Kings 6:1), fell in April–May. This was one month after the exodus (12:18).
- c (16:12) Hebrew "Between the two evenings." See the note at 12:6.
- d (16:15) Hebrew man hu, "What is it?" The phrase explains the name manna (verse 31).
- e (16:16) Hebrew "an omer." An omer was about 2 dry quarts (about 2.2 liters). See verse 36.
- f (16:18) Hebrew "when they measured it with the omer."
- g (16:22) Hebrew "two omers," about 4 dry quarts (about 4.4 liters).
- h (16:23) Hebrew shabbaton shabbat-qodesh, "a rest, a holy Sabbath." The word Sabbath comes from shavat, "to stop" or "to rest." This is the first time the word appears in the Bible.
- i (16:31) Hebrew man, "What?" (see verse 15). Numbers 11:7–9 also describes it.
- j (16:32) Hebrew "an omerful." So also in verse 33.
- k (16:34) That is, before the ark that would hold the tablets of the testimony (25:16, 21–22). The narrator speaks of the later practice.
- l (16:36) Hebrew "The omer is a tenth of the ephah." The omer was about 2.2 liters (2 dry quarts), and the ephah about 22 liters (three-fifths of a bushel). Ancient standards varied.

Chapter 17

1 The whole congregation of the Israelites set out from the wilderness of Sin, traveling in stages at Yahweh's command,[a] and camped at Rephidim.[b] But there was no water for the people to drink. 2 So the people quarreled with Moses and said, "Give us water to drink." Moses said to them, "Why do you quarrel with me? Why do you

test Yahweh?" [3] The people were thirsty there for water, and they grumbled against Moses, saying, "Why have you brought us up out of Egypt, to kill us, our children, and our livestock with thirst?" [4] Moses cried out to Yahweh, "What am I to do with this people? Before long they will stone me." [5] Yahweh said to Moses, "Go on ahead of the people and take with you some of the elders of Israel; and the staff with which you struck the Nile, take in your hand and go. [6] I will be standing there before you on the rock at Horeb; you shall strike the rock, and water will come out of it for the people to drink." Moses did so before the eyes of the elders of Israel. [7] He named the place Massah and Meribah,[c] because of the quarreling of the Israelites, and because they tested Yahweh, saying, "Is Yahweh among us or not?"

[8] Then Amalek[d] came and fought with Israel at Rephidim. [9] Moses said to Joshua,[e] "Choose men for us, and go out and fight with Amalek. Tomorrow I will stand on the top of the hill with the staff of God in my hand." [10] Joshua did as Moses had told him, fighting against Amalek; and Moses, with Aaron and Hur,[f] climbed to the top of the hill. [11] As long as Moses kept his hand raised, Israel prevailed; but when he let his hand down, Amalek prevailed. [12] Moses' hands became heavy, so they took a stone and placed it beneath him, and he sat on it; and Aaron and Hur supported his hands, one on each side, so that his hands remained steady until sunset. [13] And Joshua overwhelmed Amalek and his people with the sword.[g]

[14] Yahweh said to Moses, "Write this in a book[h] as a reminder, and recite it to Joshua: I will utterly erase the memory of Amalek from under heaven." [15] Moses built an altar and named it Yahweh Nissi,[i] [16] saying, "A hand upon the throne of Yah![j] Yahweh will be at war with Amalek from generation to generation."

Notes

- a (17:1) Hebrew "by the mouth of Yahweh."
- b (17:1) Rephidim perhaps means "resting places" or "supports." Its location is uncertain.
- c (17:7) Massah means "testing" and Meribah means "quarreling."
- d (17:8) Amalek, a desert people descended from Esau's grandson Amalek (Genesis 36:12).

- e (17:9) This is the first appearance of Joshua, Hebrew Yehoshua, "Yahweh saves." His earlier name was Hoshea, "salvation" (Numbers 13:16). The Greek form of the name is Iesous, "Jesus."
- f (17:10) Hur perhaps means "child" or is of Egyptian origin, from the god Horus. Jewish tradition made him Miriam's husband. See also 24:14.
- g (17:13) Hebrew "by the mouth of the sword."
- h (17:14) Or "on a scroll." Hebrew sefer, "a written document."
- i (17:15) Yahweh Nissi means "Yahweh is my banner." A banner was a pole or standard raised as a rallying point in battle, recalling Moses' raised staff.
- j (17:16) The Hebrew is difficult. It may mean "a hand raised to the throne of Yah," an oath, or, if kes ("throne") is read as nes ("banner"), "a hand upon the banner of Yah," matching the name Yahweh Nissi. The Septuagint reads "with a secret hand the Lord wars against Amalek." On Yah, see the note at 15:2.

Chapter 18

1 Jethro, the priest of Midian, Moses' father-in-law, heard of all that
God had done for Moses and for his people Israel, how Yahweh had
brought Israel out of Egypt. 2 Jethro, the father-in-law of Moses, had
taken Zipporah, Moses' wife, after she had been sent away,[a] 3 along
with her two sons. The name of the one was Gershom, for he said, "I
have become a foreigner in a foreign land," 4 and the name of the other
was Eliezer,[b] for he said, "The God of my father was my help and
rescued me from the sword of Pharaoh." 5 Jethro, Moses' father-in-
law, came with Moses' sons and his wife to Moses in the wilderness,
where he was camped at the mountain of God. 6 He sent word to
Moses,[c] "I, your father-in-law Jethro, am coming to you with your
wife and her two sons with her." 7 Moses went out to meet his father-
in-law. He bowed down and kissed him, and they asked each other
about their welfare, and they went into the tent. 8 Moses recounted to
his father-in-law everything that Yahweh had done to Pharaoh and
the Egyptians on Israel's account, all the hardship that had befallen
them along the way, and how Yahweh had delivered them. 9 Jethro
was glad because of all the good that Yahweh had done for Israel,
since he had delivered them out of the hand of the Egyptians. 10 Jethro
said, "Blessed be Yahweh, who has rescued you from the hand of the
Egyptians and from the hand of Pharaoh, who has rescued the people
from under the hand of the Egyptians. 11 Now I know that Yahweh is

greater than all gods, because of what came about when they acted insolently against the people."[d] 12 Then Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, brought a burnt offering and sacrifices to God, and Aaron came with all the elders of Israel to eat bread with Moses' father-in-law before God.

13 The next day Moses sat to judge the people, and the people stood around Moses from morning until evening. 14 When Moses' father-in-law saw all that he was doing for the people, he said, "What is this that you are doing for the people? Why do you sit alone, with all the people standing around you from morning until evening?" 15 Moses said to his father-in-law, "Because the people come to me to inquire of God. 16 When they have a dispute, it comes to me, and I judge between one person and another, and I make known the statutes of God and his laws." 17 Moses' father-in-law said to him, "What you are doing is not good. 18 You will certainly wear yourself out, you and this people who are with you, for the work is too heavy for you; you are not able to do it by yourself. 19 Now listen to me; let me counsel you, and may God be with you. Be the people's representative before God, and bring their cases to him. 20 Teach them the statutes and the laws, and make known to them the way in which they must walk and the work they must do. 21 Moreover you shall look out from among all the people capable men, such as fear God, men of truth, hating unjust gain; and place such over them as rulers of thousands, rulers of hundreds, rulers of fifties, and rulers of tens. 22 Let them judge the people at all times. Every major dispute they are to bring to you, but every minor dispute they may decide themselves. So it will be easier for you, and they will bear the burden with you. 23 If you do this, and God so commands you, then you will be able to endure, and all these people also will go to their place in peace."

24 So Moses listened to the voice of his father-in-law and did all that he had said. 25 Moses chose capable men out of all Israel and made them heads over the people, officers over thousands, officers over hundreds, officers over fifties, and officers over tens.[e] 26 They judged the people at all times. Any difficult case they brought to Moses,

but every minor case they decided themselves. 27 Then Moses let his father-in-law depart, and he went away to his own land.

Notes

- a (18:2) Hebrew shilluheha, "her sending away." The text does not say when or why Moses sent her back; the last mention of her is 4:20–26.
- b (18:4) Eliezer means "my God is help."
- c (18:6) So the Hebrew. The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, and the Syriac read "Someone said to Moses, 'Look, your father-in-law Jethro is coming to you.'"
- d (18:11) The Hebrew of the last part of the verse is brief and difficult, literally "for in the thing in which they acted proudly against them."
- e (18:25) At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds a passage drawn from Deuteronomy 1:9–18, in which Moses describes the appointment of the judges in his own words.

Chapter 19

1 In the third month (in May–June)[a] after the Israelites had gone out of the land of Egypt, on that very day,[b] they came into the wilderness of Sinai. 2 They set out from Rephidim, came into the wilderness of Sinai, and camped in the wilderness. Israel camped there in front of the mountain. 3 Moses went up to God, and Yahweh called to him from the mountain, saying, "This is what you are to say to the house of Jacob and tell the Israelites: 4 'You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I carried you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself. 5 And now, if you will truly obey my voice and keep my covenant, you shall be my own treasured possession[c] among all the peoples; for the whole earth is mine. 6 You will be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation.' These are the words that you are to speak to the Israelites."

7 So Moses came and called the elders of the people and set before them all these words that Yahweh had commanded him. 8 The whole people answered as one, "Everything that Yahweh has spoken we will do." Then Moses reported the people's words to Yahweh. 9 Yahweh said to Moses, "Look, I am coming to you in a thick cloud, so that the people may hear when I speak with you and may also believe you forever." Then Moses told the people's words to Yahweh.

10 Yahweh said to Moses, "Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow. Let them wash their clothes 11 and be ready for the

third day, for on the third day Yahweh will come down on Mount Sinai in the sight of all the people. 12 You shall mark off a boundary for the people all around and say, 'Beware of going up the mountain or touching its border; anyone who touches the mountain shall surely be put to death. 13 No hand shall touch him, but he shall be stoned or shot with arrows; beast or man, he shall not live. When the ram's horn gives a long blast, they may go up on the mountain."[d] 14 Moses came down from the mountain to the people and sanctified the people, and they washed their garments. 15 He said to the people, "Be ready for the third day. Do not go near a woman."

16 On the third day, as morning came, there were thunder and lightning, a dense cloud over the mountain, and a very loud trumpet blast, and all the people in the camp shuddered. 17 Moses led the people out of the camp to meet God, and they stationed themselves at the base of the mountain. 18 Mount Sinai was entirely in smoke, because Yahweh had descended upon it in fire; its smoke rose like the smoke of a furnace, and the whole mountain[e] shook violently. 19 As the sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses spoke, and God answered him with a voice.[f] 20 Yahweh came down on Mount Sinai, on the top of the mountain. Yahweh called Moses to the top of the mountain, and Moses went up. 21 Yahweh said to Moses, "Go down and warn the people, so that they do not break through to Yahweh to look, and many of them perish. 22 Even the priests who come near to Yahweh must consecrate themselves, or Yahweh will break out against them." 23 Moses said to Yahweh, "The people cannot come up to Mount Sinai, because you yourself charged us, 'Mark off boundaries around the mountain and make it holy.'" 24 Yahweh said to him, "Go down, and then come up, you together with Aaron; but the priests and the people must not break through to come up to Yahweh, lest he burst out against them." 25 So Moses went down to the people and told them.

Notes

- a (19:1) Hebrew "In the third month," later called Sivan, counting from the spring new year (see the note at 12:2).
- b (19:1) Literally "on this day," probably the first day of the month, the new moon.
- c (19:5) Hebrew segullah, a personal treasure, such as a king's private property.

- d (19:13) Hebrew yovel, “ram’s horn.” The trumpet (shofar) of verses 16 and 19 is a different word for a similar instrument.
- e (19:18) The Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts read “the whole people.”
- f (19:19) Or “in thunder.” The Hebrew word qol means both “voice” and “thunder.”

Chapter 20

1 Then God spoke all these words, saying,[a] 2 “I am Yahweh your God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery.
3 “You shall have no other gods before me.[b]
4 “You shall not make yourself a carved image,[c] nor any likeness of
what is in the heavens above, or on the earth beneath, or in the waters
under the earth. 5 You shall not bow down to them nor serve them; for
I, Yahweh your God, am a jealous God,[d] punishing the iniquity of the
fathers upon the children, upon the third and upon the fourth gener-
ation of those who hate me, 6 but showing loyal love to thousands[e] of
those who love me and keep my commandments.
7 “You shall not take up the name of Yahweh your God for emptiness,[f]
for Yahweh will not leave unpunished anyone who takes up his name
for emptiness.
8 “Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. 9 Six days you shall
labor and do all your work, 10 but the seventh day is a Sabbath to
Yahweh your God: you shall do no work on it—you, nor your son, nor
your daughter, nor your male servant, nor your female servant, nor
your livestock, nor the sojourner within your gates. 11 For in six days
Yahweh made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and everything in
them, and he rested on the seventh day; this is why Yahweh blessed
the Sabbath day and hallowed it.
12 “Honor your father and your mother, so that your days may be long
in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you.
13 “You shall not murder.[g]
14 “You shall not commit adultery.
15 “You shall not steal.
16 “You shall not give false testimony against your neighbor.

17 “You shall not covet your neighbor’s house; you shall not covet your
neighbor’s wife, nor his male servant, nor his female servant, nor his
ox, nor his donkey, nor anything that is your neighbor’s.”[h]
18 All the people saw the thunder and the lightning, the sound of the
trumpet, and the mountain smoking. When the people saw it, they
trembled and stood at a distance. 19 They said to Moses, “You speak
to us, and we will hear; but let not God speak to us, lest we die.” 20
Moses said to the people, “Do not be afraid, for God has come to test
you, and so that the fear of him may be before you, to keep you from
sinning.” 21 So the people stood far off, but Moses approached the thick
darkness where God was.[i]
22 Yahweh said to Moses, “This is what you are to say to the Israelites:
‘You yourselves have seen that I have spoken with you from heaven.
23 You shall not make alongside me gods of silver, and gods of gold
you shall not make for yourselves. 24 You are to make for me an
altar of earth and sacrifice on it your burnt offerings and your peace
offerings,[j] your sheep and your oxen. In every place where I cause
my name to be remembered I will come to you and bless you. 25 If you
make me an altar of stone, you shall not build it with hewn stones;
for if you wield your chisel on it, you have profaned it. 26 And you
shall not go up by steps to my altar, so that your nakedness may not
be exposed on it.’

Notes

- a (20:1) The Ten Commandments, called in Hebrew “the ten words” (34:28; Deuteronomy 4:13), are given again in Deuteronomy 5:6–21 with some differences. Jewish and Christian traditions divide them in different ways.
- b (20:3) Or “besides me,” or “in defiance of me.” Literally “before my face.”
- c (20:4) Hebrew pesel, an idol carved from wood or stone, or cast in metal.
- d (20:5) Hebrew El qanna, “a jealous God,” one who is zealous for an exclusive relationship, as a husband for his marriage. See 34:14, where Qanna is given as a name.
- e (20:6) Or “to the thousandth generation,” in contrast with the third and fourth generation of verse 5. Compare Deuteronomy 7:9. On “loyal love,” see the note at 15:13.
- f (20:7) Or “You shall not misuse the name” or “lift up the name … in vain.” The command forbids using God’s name for falsehood, such as false oaths, or for worthless ends.

- g (20:13) Hebrew ratsah, unlawful killing. The word is not used for killing in war or for lawful execution. The Septuagint (Vaticanus) gives verses 13–15 in the order "You shall not commit adultery. You shall not steal. You shall not murder."
- h (20:17) After this verse the Samaritan Pentateuch adds a commandment, drawn from Deuteronomy 11:29–30 and 27:2–7, to build an altar on Mount Gerizim.
- i (20:21) In verses 19–21 the Samaritan Pentateuch adds passages drawn from Deuteronomy 5:24–31 and 18:18–22, including the promise of a prophet like Moses.
- j (20:24) Hebrew shelamim, offerings for fellowship, thanksgiving, or vows, shared by the worshiper, the priests, and God.

Chapter 21

1 "These are the rules[a] that you are to set before them.
2 "When you buy a Hebrew slave,[b] he is to serve six years, and in the
seventh he is to go out free, without payment. 3 If he comes in single,
he is to go out single. If he is married, his wife is to go out with him.
4 If his master gives him a wife, and she bears him sons or daughters,
the wife and her children shall be her master's, and he shall go out
by himself. 5 But if the slave plainly says, 'I love my master, my wife,
and my children; I will not go out free,' 6 then his master shall bring
him to God,[c] and shall bring him to the door or to the doorpost; and
his master shall pierce his ear with an awl, and he shall serve him
forever.
7 "When a man sells his daughter as a slave, she is not to go out as the
male slaves do. 8 If she displeases her master, who had designated her
for himself,[d] then he shall let her be redeemed. To sell her to a foreign
people he shall have no power, seeing he has dealt deceitfully with
her. 9 If he designates her for his son, he is to deal with her as with a
daughter. 10 If he takes another wife for himself, he must not reduce
her food, her clothing, or her marital rights.[e] 11 If he does not do these
three things for her, she is to go out free, without payment of money.
12 "Whoever strikes a man so that he dies shall surely be put to death.
13 But if he did not lie in wait for him, and God let him fall into his
hand, then I will appoint for you a place to which he may flee. 14 But if
a man acts willfully against his neighbor to kill him by cunning, you
are to take him even from my altar, so that he may die.
15 "Whoever strikes his father or his mother shall surely be put to
death.

16 “Whoever kidnaps a man, whether he has sold him or he is still
found in his possession, must surely be put to death.
17 “Whoever curses[f] his father or his mother shall surely be put to
death.
18 “If men quarrel, and one strikes the other with a stone or with his
fist, and he does not die but keeps to his bed, 19 then if he gets up and
walks around outside with his staff, the one who struck him will be
free of liability. He must only pay for the loss of his time and see that
he is fully healed.
20 “When a man strikes his male or female slave with a rod and the
slave dies under his hand, the slave must be avenged. 21 Yet if the slave
lives on a day or two, he shall not be avenged, for he is the owner’s
money.[g]
22 “If men fight with one another and hurt a pregnant woman so that
her children come out,[h] and yet no harm follows, he shall surely be
fined, according to what the woman’s husband lays on him; and he
shall pay as the judges determine. 23 But if there is serious injury, then
you are to give life for life, 24 eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand,
foot for foot, 25 burn for burn, wound for wound, bruise for bruise.[i]
26 “When a man strikes the eye of his male or female slave and destroys
it, he is to let the slave go free in compensation for the eye. 27 If he
knocks out the tooth of his male or female slave, he is to let the slave
go free in compensation for the tooth.
28 “If an ox gores a man or a woman so that either dies, the ox shall
surely be stoned, and its flesh shall not be eaten; but the owner of the
ox shall be free of blame. 29 But if the ox was accustomed to goring in
time past, and its owner was warned but did not confine it, and it kills
a man or a woman, the ox shall be stoned, and its owner also shall
be put to death. 30 If a ransom is imposed on him, then he is to give
for the redemption of his life whatever is imposed on him. 31 Whether
it gores a son or gores a daughter, it shall be done to him according
to this same judgment. 32 If the ox gores a male or female slave, the
owner is to give to their master about 12 ounces of silver,[j] and the ox
is to be stoned.

33 “If a man opens a pit, or if a man digs a pit and does not cover it, and
an ox or a donkey falls in, 34 the owner of the pit is to make it good.
He is to pay money to its owner, and the dead animal will be his.
35 “When one man’s ox injures his neighbor’s ox so that it dies, they
are to sell the live ox and divide its price, and they are also to divide
the dead animal. 36 Or if it is known that the ox has been in the habit
of goring in the past, and its owner has not kept it in, he must surely
repay ox for ox, and the dead animal will be his.

Notes

- a (21:1) Hebrew mishpatim, “judgments” or “ordinances,” case laws that apply the covenant. Chapters 21–23 are often called the Book of the Covenant (24:7).
- b (21:2) Or “servant.” Hebrew eved means a slave or servant, including a person in debt service, as here, who serves for a limited term.
- c (21:6) Or “to the judges.” Hebrew elohim may refer to God at the sanctuary or to judges acting in his name. So also in 22:8–9.
- d (21:8) So the main Hebrew reading. The traditional Hebrew margin and the Samaritan Pentateuch read “so that he has not designated her.”
- e (21:10) Or “her shelter” or “her ointment.” The Hebrew word onah occurs only here, and its meaning is uncertain.
- f (21:17) Or “treats with contempt.” Hebrew qillel, “make light of.”
- g (21:21) Hebrew “for he is his money.”
- h (21:22) That is, she gives birth prematurely, or perhaps miscarries. The phrase “no serious injury” (Hebrew ason, “harm”) may refer to the woman, the child, or both; interpreters differ. The Septuagint distinguishes a child born “not fully formed,” for which a fine is paid, from one “fully formed,” for which the penalty is life for life.
- i (21:25) The principle of equal justice (lex talionis) set the limit of a penalty and was generally applied through monetary compensation.
- j (21:32) Hebrew “thirty shekels of silver,” about 12 ounces (345 grams). Compare Zechariah 11:12–13 and Matthew 26:15.

Chapter 22

1 “If a man steals an ox or a sheep[a] and kills it or sells it, he shall
pay back five oxen for the ox, and four sheep for the sheep. 2 If the
thief is found breaking in, and is struck so that he dies, there shall be
no bloodguilt on his account. 3 If the sun has risen on him, blood is
due for him. He must make full restitution; and if he has nothing, he
shall be sold for his theft. 4 If the stolen animal is found alive in his
possession, whether ox or donkey or sheep, he is to repay double.

5 “When a man lets a field or vineyard be grazed over, or lets his animal
loose and it grazes in another man’s field, he is to make restitution
from the best of his own field and the best of his own vineyard.[b]
6 “If fire breaks out and spreads to thorns, and the shocks of grain, or
the standing grain, or the field are consumed, he who kindled the fire
shall surely make restitution.
7 “If a man gives money or articles to his neighbor for safekeeping, and
it is stolen out of that man’s house, and the thief is caught, he shall
pay back double. 8 If the thief is not found, the owner of the house
is to come near to God[c] to show whether he has put his hand to his
neighbor’s property. 9 For every kind of breach of trust, whether for
ox, donkey, sheep, clothing, or any lost thing about which one says,
‘This is it,’ the cause of both parties shall come before God; whomever
God condemns[d] shall pay double to his neighbor.
10 “When a man gives his neighbor a donkey, an ox, a sheep, or any
animal to keep, and it dies or is injured or is driven away, with no
one seeing it, 11 an oath of Yahweh shall be between the two of them,
whether he has put his hand to his neighbor’s goods; and its owner
shall accept it, and he shall not make restitution. 12 But if it was
actually stolen from him, he is to make restitution to its owner. 13 If
it has been torn to pieces by a beast, let him bring it as evidence; he
need not pay for what was torn.
14 “When a man borrows an animal from his neighbor, and it is injured
or dies while its owner is not with it, he must make full restitution.
15 If its owner was with it, he does not have to make restitution. If it
was hired, the hiring fee covers the loss.[e]
16 “If a man entices a virgin who is not betrothed and lies with her,
he shall certainly endow her to be his wife by paying the bride price.[f]
17 If her father utterly refuses to give her to him, he is to pay money
equal to the bride-price for virgins.
18 “You shall not let a sorceress live.
19 “Whoever lies with an animal must surely be put to death.
20 “Whoever sacrifices to any god other than Yahweh alone is to be
devoted to destruction.[g]

21 “You shall not wrong a foreigner or oppress him, for you were
foreigners in the land of Egypt. 22 You shall not mistreat any widow
or orphan. 23 If you do mistreat them, and they cry out to me, I will
surely hear their cry, 24 and my anger will burn, and I will kill you with
the sword, and your wives will become widows and your children
orphans.
25 “If you lend money to any of my people with you who is poor, you
shall not act like a moneylender to him; you shall not charge him
interest. 26 If you take your neighbor’s garment in pledge, you shall
return it to him before the sun sets, 27 for that is his only covering, it
is his garment for his skin. In what shall he sleep? And when he cries
to me, I will hear, for I am gracious.
28 “You shall not revile God,[h] nor curse a ruler of your people.
29 “You shall not hold back the first of your ripe harvest and of the
overflow of your presses.[i] The firstborn of your sons you shall give to
me. 30 You are to do the same with your oxen and your sheep. Seven
days it is to be with its mother; on the eighth day you are to give it
to me.
31 “You are to be holy people to me. Therefore you shall not eat any
meat that is torn by beasts in the field; you are to throw it to the dogs.

Notes

- a (22:1) Verse 22:1 is numbered 21:37 in the Hebrew text, and verses 22:2–31 are numbered 22:1–30.
- b (22:5) The Samaritan Pentateuch and the Septuagint have a longer text: “… he is to make restitution from his own field according to its yield. But if it grazes over the whole field, he is to make restitution from the best of his own field and the best of his own vineyard.”
- c (22:8) Or “before the judges.” See the note at 21:6.
- d (22:9) Or “whom the judges declare guilty.” The verb is plural, which may suggest judges acting for God.
- e (22:15) Or “if it was hired, he must bear the loss of the hire.” The Hebrew is brief, literally “if it was hired, it came for its hire.”
- f (22:16) Hebrew mohar, the payment a bridegroom gave to the bride’s family.
- g (22:20) Hebrew herem, set apart irrevocably to God, which in the case of a person meant death.
- h (22:28) Or “the judges.” Hebrew elohim. Paul quotes the second half of this verse in Acts 23:5.

- i (22:29) The Hebrew is brief: “your fullness and your trickling,” that is, the first of the grain harvest and of the juice from the wine press and olive press.

Chapter 23

1 “You shall not spread a false report. Do not join hands with a wicked
person to be a malicious witness. 2 You shall not follow a crowd in
doing evil, nor shall you testify in a lawsuit siding with a crowd to
pervert justice. 3 Nor shall you show partiality to a poor man in his
lawsuit.
4 “If you meet your enemy’s ox or his donkey going astray, you must
take it back to him. 5 If you see the donkey of one who hates you lying
down under its load, you shall not leave him alone with it; you must
help him free it.[a]
6 “You shall not turn aside the justice owed to your poor in his dispute.
7 Keep far from a false charge, and do not kill the innocent and the
righteous, for I will not acquit the wicked. 8 You shall not take a
bribe, for a bribe blinds those who see and subverts the cause of the
righteous. 9 “You shall not oppress a stranger; you yourselves know
the life[b] of a stranger, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt.
10 “For six years you are to sow your land and gather in its produce, 11
but in the seventh year you are to let it rest and lie fallow, so that the
poor of your people may eat. What they leave, the wild animals may
eat. You are to do the same with your vineyard and your olive grove.
12 For six days you shall do your work, but on the seventh day you
shall cease, that your ox and your donkey may rest, and the female
servant’s son and the resident alien may be refreshed. 13 Take heed to
everything I have said to you; do not make mention of the names of
other gods, nor let them be heard from your lips.
14 “You shall keep a feast to me three times in the year. 15 You are to
keep the Festival of Unleavened Bread. For seven days you are to eat
unleavened bread, as I commanded you, at the appointed time in the
month of Abib (March–April),[c] for in it you came out of Egypt. No one
is to appear before me empty-handed. 16 Also the Feast of Harvest,[d]
the firstfruits of your labors, which you sow in the field; and the Feast
of Ingathering[e] at the end of the year, when you gather in the produce

of your labors from the field. 17 Three times a year all your males are to appear before the Lord Yahweh.[f]
18 "You shall not offer the blood of my sacrifice with anything leavened, and the fat of my festival sacrifice is not to remain until morning. 19 The best of the firstfruits of your ground you are to bring into the house of Yahweh your God. "You shall not boil a young goat in its mother's milk.[g]
20 "Look, I am sending an angel before you to guard you on the way and to bring you to the place I have prepared. 21 Take heed before him and obey his voice; do not provoke him, for he will not forgive your transgressions, since my name is in him. 22 But if you carefully listen to his voice and do all that I say, then I will be an enemy to your enemies and an adversary to your adversaries. 23 For my angel will go before you and bring you to the Amorites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Canaanites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites, and I will wipe them out. 24 You shall not bow down to their gods or serve them, nor do as they do, but you are to demolish them completely and break their sacred pillars in pieces. 25 You are to serve Yahweh your God, and he will bless your bread and your water, and I will take sickness away from among you. 26 No woman will miscarry or be barren in your land; I will fulfill the number of your days.
27 "I will send my terror before you and throw into confusion all the people against whom you come, and I will make all your enemies turn their backs to you. 28 I will send the hornet[h] before you, which will drive out the Hivites, the Canaanites, and the Hittites from before you. 29 I will not drive them out from before you in one year, lest the land become desolate, and the beasts of the field multiply against you. 30 Little by little I will drive them out from before you, until you have increased and take possession of the land. 31 I will set your border from the Red Sea to the Sea of the Philistines,[i] and from the wilderness to the River,[j] for I will give the inhabitants of the land into your hand, and you will drive them out before you. 32 You shall make no covenant with them or with their gods. 33 They shall not dwell in your land, lest they cause you to sin against me; for if you serve their gods, it will surely be a snare to you."

Notes

- a (23:5) The Hebrew is difficult; literally, "you shall cease from leaving it to him; you shall certainly loose it along with him."
- b (23:9) Hebrew nefesh, "soul," "life," or "inner feelings."
- c (23:15) Hebrew "the month of Abib." See the note at 13:4.
- d (23:16) That is, the wheat harvest in late spring, later called the Festival of Weeks (34:22) or Pentecost.
- e (23:16) That is, the autumn harvest of fruit and olives, later called the Festival of Booths or Tabernacles.
- f (23:17) Hebrew ha'adon YHWH, "the Lord, Yahweh." Here Adon ("Lord" or "Master") is used, not Adonai.
- g (23:19) This command is repeated in 34:26 and Deuteronomy 14:21. Its original purpose is uncertain; it may forbid a Canaanite ritual or express respect for the bond between mother and young. It became the basis of the Jewish practice of not mixing meat and milk.
- h (23:28) Or "panic" or "plague." The meaning of the Hebrew word tsir'ah is uncertain.
- i (23:31) That is, the Mediterranean Sea.
- j (23:31) That is, the Euphrates.

Chapter 24

1 Then he said to Moses, "Come up to Yahweh, you and Aaron, Nadab,
and Abihu, and seventy of the elders of Israel, and worship at a
distance. 2 Moses alone is to come near to Yahweh, but the others are
not to come near, and the people are not to come up with him."
3 Moses came and told the people all the words of Yahweh and all
the rules. All the people answered with one voice and said, "All the
words that Yahweh has spoken we will do." 4 Moses wrote down all
the words of Yahweh. He rose early in the morning and built an altar
at the foot of the mountain, and twelve pillars, for the twelve tribes
of Israel. 5 He sent young men of the Israelites, and they offered burnt
offerings and sacrificed peace offerings of bulls to Yahweh. 6 Moses
took half of the blood and put it in basins, and half of the blood he
splashed against the altar. 7 Then he took the Book of the Covenant
and read it in the hearing of the people. They said, "All that Yahweh
has spoken we will do, and we will obey." 8 Moses took the blood and
splashed it on the people and said, "This is the blood of the covenant
that Yahweh has made with you in accordance with all these words."[a]

9 Then Moses and Aaron, Nadab and Abihu, and seventy of the elders
of Israel went up. 10 They saw the God of Israel.[b] Under his feet there
was something like a pavement of lapis lazuli,[c] like the very sky for
clearness. 11 But he did not lay his hand on the leaders[d] of the Israelites.
They beheld God, and they ate and drank.
12 Yahweh said to Moses, "Come up to me on the mountain and stay
there, and I will give you the tablets of stone, with the law and the
commandment that I have written for their instruction." 13 So Moses
set out with Joshua his assistant, and Moses went up the mountain
of God. 14 He said to the elders, "Stay here for us until we come back
to you; and see, Aaron and Hur are with you. Whoever has a legal
matter may go to them."
15 Then Moses went up the mountain, and the cloud covered the
mountain. 16 The glory of Yahweh settled on Mount Sinai, and the
cloud covered it six days. On the seventh day he called to Moses
from the midst of the cloud. 17 The appearance of the glory of Yahweh
was like a consuming fire on the top of the mountain in the sight of
the Israelites. 18 Moses entered the cloud and went up the mountain.
Moses was on the mountain forty days and forty nights.

Notes

- a (24:8) Jesus echoes these words at the Last Supper (Matthew 26:28; Mark 14:24); compare Hebrews 9:18–20.
- b (24:10) The Septuagint reads "they saw the place where the God of Israel stood," and in verse 11 "they appeared in the place of God," softening the statement that they saw God.
- c (24:10) Or "sapphire." The ancient sapphire was probably lapis lazuli, a deep blue stone.
- d (24:11) Hebrew atsilim, "corners" or "nobles," a rare word.

Chapter 25

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites, that they
bring me a contribution;[a] from every man whose heart prompts him
you shall take my contribution. 3 This is the offering that you are to
receive from them: gold, silver, and bronze;[b] 4 blue, purple, and scarlet
yarn,[c] fine linen, and goats' hair; 5 rams' skins dyed red, fine leather,[d]
and acacia wood;[e] 6 oil for the light, spices for the anointing oil and

for the fragrant incense; 7 onyx stones[f] and stones to be set, for the
ephod[g] and for the breastpiece. 8 Let them make me a sanctuary, that
I may dwell among them. 9 Exactly as I show you, the pattern of the
tabernacle[h] and the pattern of all its furnishings, so you are to make it.
10 "They are to make an ark[i] of acacia wood, about 3¾ feet long, 2¼ feet
wide, and 2¼ feet high.[j] 11 You are to overlay it with pure gold, inside
and outside you are to overlay it, and you are to make a molding of
gold around it. 12 You are to cast four rings of gold for it and fasten
them on its four feet, two rings on one side of it and two rings on the
other side. 13 You are to make poles of acacia wood and overlay them
with gold. 14 You are to put the poles into the rings on the sides of the
ark, to carry the ark by them. 15 The poles are to remain in the rings
of the ark; they must not be removed from it. 16 You are to put into
the ark the testimony[k] that I will give you.
17 "You are to make an atonement cover[l] of pure gold, about 3¾ feet
long and 2¼ feet wide.[m] 18 You shall make two cherubim[n] of gold; make
them of beaten work, at the two ends of the mercy seat. 19 Make one
cherub at the one end, and at the other end the other; the cherubim
you shall make of one piece with the mercy seat, at its two ends. 20
The cherubim shall spread their wings upward, covering the mercy
seat with their wings, and their faces shall look toward each other;
toward the mercy seat shall be the faces of the cherubim. 21 You shall
place the mercy seat on the top of the ark, and into the ark you shall
put the testimony that I shall give you. 22 There I will meet with you;
from above the mercy seat, between the two cherubim over the ark
of the testimony, I will speak with you about all that I shall command
you for the Israelites.
23 "You are to make a table of acacia wood, about 3 feet long, 1½ feet
wide, and 2¼ feet high.[o] 24 You are to overlay it with pure gold and
make a molding of gold around it. 25 You are to make a rim around it
about 3 inches wide,[p] and make a molding of gold around the rim. 26
You are to make four rings of gold for it and fasten the rings at the
four corners at its four legs. 27 Close to the rim the rings shall be, as
places for the poles to carry the table. 28 You are to make the poles
of acacia wood and overlay them with gold, and the table is to be

carried with them. 29 You are to make its plates and its dishes, its jars
and its bowls for pouring out drink offerings; you are to make them
of pure gold. 30 And you are to set the bread of the Presence[q] on the
table before me always.
31 "You shall make a lampstand[r] of pure gold; of hammered work the
lampstand shall be made, its base and its stem; its cups, its knobs,[s]
and its flowers shall be of one piece with it. 32 Six branches are to go
out from its sides, three branches of the lampstand from one side of
it and three branches of the lampstand from the other side of it. 33 On
one branch are to be three cups shaped like almond blossoms, each
with a knob and a flower, and on the next branch three cups shaped
like almond blossoms, each with a knob and a flower; so for the six
branches going out from the lampstand. 34 On the lampstand itself are
to be four cups shaped like almond blossoms, with their knobs and
flowers, 35 and a knob under the first pair of branches, of one piece
with it, and a knob under the second pair of branches, of one piece
with it, and a knob under the third pair of branches, of one piece with
it, for the six branches going out from the lampstand. 36 Their knobs
and their branches shall be of one piece with it; all of it one piece of
hammered work of pure gold. 37 You shall make its seven lamps; and
the lamps shall be set up to give light on the area in front of it. 38 Its
snuffers and its trays are to be of pure gold. 39 It is to be made, with
all these utensils, from about 75 pounds of pure gold.[t] 40 See that you
make them after the pattern for them that you were shown on the
mountain.

Notes

- a (25:2) Hebrew terumah, a contribution set apart, literally "something lifted off."
- b (25:3) Or "copper." Hebrew nehoshet means copper or its alloy bronze.
- c (25:4) The colors came from dyes: blue (or violet) from sea snails, purple from murex shells, and scarlet from an insect dye.
- d (25:5) Hebrew tahash. The meaning is uncertain; suggestions include the skins of dolphins or dugongs (sea cows), goatskin, or leather dyed a particular color.
- e (25:5) Acacia is a hard, durable desert wood that grows in Sinai.
- f (25:7) Or "carnelian." The identification of many ancient stones is uncertain.
- g (25:7) The ephod was an outer priestly garment, apparently a kind of apron or vest (28:6–14).

- h (25:9) Hebrew mishkan, “dwelling place,” from shakan, “to dwell” (verse 8). It was a portable tent-shrine.
- i (25:10) Hebrew aron, “chest” or “box,” a different word from Noah’s ark.
- j (25:10) Hebrew “two and a half cubits long, a cubit and a half wide, and a cubit and a half high,” about 1.1 meters long and 0.7 meter wide and high. A cubit, the distance from elbow to fingertip, was about 18 inches (45 centimeters); a longer cubit of about 20.5 inches (52 centimeters) was also used, so the measurements in these chapters may be somewhat larger.
- k (25:16) That is, the two tablets of stone, which bore witness to the covenant (31:18).
- l (25:17) Hebrew kapporet, from the verb kipper, “to atone” or “to cover.” The traditional English “mercy seat” comes from Luther’s Gnadenstuhl and Tyndale. The Septuagint reads hilasterion, “place of atonement” (compare Romans 3:25; Hebrews 9:5).
- m (25:17) Hebrew “two and a half cubits long and a cubit and a half wide,” about 1.1 by 0.7 meters.
- n (25:18) Cherubim (singular cherub) were winged heavenly beings, often pictured in the ancient Near East as guardians of thrones and holy places. Compare Genesis 3:24.
- o (25:23) Hebrew “two cubits long, a cubit wide, and a cubit and a half high,” about 90 centimeters long, 45 wide, and 70 high.
- p (25:25) Hebrew “a handbreadth,” about 3 inches (7.5 centimeters).
- q (25:30) Literally “bread of the face,” twelve loaves set before Yahweh and renewed every Sabbath (Leviticus 24:5–9).
- r (25:31) Hebrew menorah.
- s (25:31) Hebrew kaftor, probably the bulb or calyx beneath the flower.
- t (25:39) Hebrew “a talent of pure gold,” about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).

Chapter 26

1 “You are to make the tabernacle with ten curtains of fine twisted
linen, and blue, purple, and scarlet yarn; you are to make them with
cherubim worked into them by a skilled designer. 2 The length of each
curtain is to be about 42 feet, and the width of each curtain about
6 feet;[a] all the curtains are to have the same measurements. 3 Five
curtains are to be joined to one another, and the other five curtains
are to be joined to one another. 4 You are to make loops of blue on
the edge of the outermost curtain in the first set, and likewise make
them on the edge of the outermost curtain in the second set. 5 You
shall make fifty loops in the one curtain, and fifty loops in the edge of
the curtain that is in the second set, so that the loops are opposite one

another. 6 You shall make fifty clasps of gold, and couple the curtains
to one another with the clasps, so that the tabernacle may be one.
7 "You shall also make curtains of goats' hair for a tent over the taber-
nacle; eleven curtains you shall make. 8 The length of each curtain is
to be about 45 feet, and the width of each curtain about 6 feet;[b] the
eleven curtains are to have the same measurements. 9 You are to join
five curtains by themselves and six curtains by themselves, and you
are to fold the sixth curtain double at the front of the tent. 10 You are to
make fifty loops on the edge of the outermost curtain in the first set
and fifty loops on the edge of the curtain in the second set. 11 And you
shall make fifty hooks of bronze, and put the hooks into the loops, and
join the tent together, that it may be one. 12 And the overlapping part
that remains of the curtains of the tent, the half curtain that remains,
shall hang over the back of the tabernacle. 13 The extra length of the
curtains of the tent, about 18 inches[c] on one side and about 18 inches
on the other, is to hang over the sides of the tabernacle, on this side
and that, to cover it. 14 You are to make for the tent a covering of rams'
skins dyed red, and a covering of fine leather above that.
15 "You are to make upright frames[d] of acacia wood for the tabernacle.
16 The length of each frame is to be about 15 feet, and the width of
each frame about 2¼ feet.[e] 17 Each frame is to have two tenons,[f] joined
to one another. You are to make all the frames of the tabernacle this
way. 18 You shall make the frames for the tabernacle: twenty frames
on the south side, toward the south; 19 Forty sockets[g] of silver you
shall make under the twenty boards: two sockets under the one board
for its two tenons, and two sockets under the next board for its two
tenons; 20 and for the second side of the tabernacle, the north side,
twenty frames, 21 and their forty sockets of silver, two sockets under
the one board, and two sockets under the next board. 22 And for the
rear of the tabernacle toward the west you shall make six frames. 23
You are to make two frames for the corners of the tabernacle at the
rear. 24 They are to be doubled at the bottom and likewise complete[h]
at the top, up to the first ring. So it is to be for both of them; they will
form the two corners. 25 There shall be eight boards, and their sockets

of silver, sixteen sockets; two sockets under the one board, and two sockets under the next board.
26 “You shall make bars of acacia wood; five for the boards of one side
of the tabernacle, 27 and five bars for the boards of the other side of the
tabernacle, and five bars for the boards of the side of the tabernacle
at the rear toward the west. 28 The middle crossbar, halfway up the
frames, is to run from end to end. 29 You shall overlay the boards with
gold, and make their rings of gold for places for the bars, and you shall
overlay the bars with gold. 30 And you shall raise up the tabernacle
according to the plan that was shown you on the mountain.
31 “You shall make a veil[i] of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn and fine
twisted linen; with cherubim skillfully worked into it it shall be made.
32 You are to hang it on four posts of acacia overlaid with gold, with
hooks of gold, set on four bases of silver. 33 And you shall hang the
veil under the hooks, and bring the ark of the testimony in behind
the veil; the veil shall make a division for you between the Holy Place
and the Most Holy Place.[j] 34 You shall set the mercy seat upon the ark
of the testimony in the Most Holy Place. 35 And you shall set the table
outside the veil, with the lampstand opposite the table on the south
side of the tabernacle; the table you shall put on the north side.
36 “You shall make a hanging for the door of the tent, embroidered with
needlework, of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen.
37 And you shall make for the hanging five pillars of acacia wood and
overlay them with gold; their hooks shall be of gold, and you shall
cast five sockets of bronze for them.

Notes

- a (26:2) Hebrew “twenty-eight cubits” long and “four cubits” wide, about 12.6 by 1.8 meters. On the cubit, see the note at 25:10.
- b (26:8) Hebrew “thirty cubits” long and “four cubits” wide, about 13.5 by 1.8 meters.
- c (26:13) Hebrew “a cubit,” about 45 centimeters.
- d (26:15) Hebrew qerashim, traditionally “boards.” They may have been open frameworks rather than solid planks.
- e (26:16) Hebrew “ten cubits” long and “a cubit and a half” wide, about 4.5 by 0.7 meters.
- f (26:17) Hebrew “hands,” projections fitting into the bases.

- g (26:19) Or “sockets,” hollow bases into which the tenons fit.
- h (26:24) Or “joined.” The construction of the corner frames is uncertain.
- i (26:31) Hebrew parokhet, the inner curtain that closed off the Most Holy Place.
- j (26:33) Hebrew “the holy of holies.”

Chapter 27

1 “You are to make the altar of acacia wood, about 7½ feet long and 7½
feet wide. The altar is to be square, and it is to be about 4½ feet high.[a]
2 You are to make its horns[b] on its four corners; its horns are to be
of one piece with it, and you are to overlay it with bronze. 3 You are
to make its pots for removing its ashes, and its shovels, its basins, its
forks, and its firepans. You are to make all its utensils of bronze. 4 You
shall make for it a grating of bronze network, and upon the network
you shall make four bronze rings at its four corners. 5 You are to set
it under the ledge of the altar, so that the network extends halfway
down the altar. 6 You are to make poles for the altar, poles of acacia
wood, and overlay them with bronze. 7 Its poles shall be put into the
rings, and the poles shall be on the two sides of the altar, to carry it.
8 You are to make it hollow, of boards. As it was shown you on the
mountain, so are they to make it.
9 “You shall make the court of the tabernacle. On the south side,
toward the south, the court shall have hangings of fine twisted linen,
about 150 feet in length[c] for one side; 10 with their twenty posts
and their twenty bases of bronze; the hooks of the posts and their
bands[d] are to be of silver. 11 Likewise for the north side, the length
is to be hangings about 150 feet long, with their twenty posts and
their twenty bases of bronze; the hooks of the posts and their bands
are to be of silver. 12 And for the breadth of the court on the west
side there shall be hangings of about 75 feet,[e] with ten pillars and
ten sockets. 13 The width of the courtyard on the front, to the east,
is to be about 75 feet. 14 The hangings for one side of the entrance
are to be about 22½ feet long,[f] with their three posts and their three
bases. 15 On the other side the hangings are to be about 22½ feet long,
with their three posts and their three bases. 16 And for the gate of the
court a hanging of about 30 feet[g] of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn and
fine twisted linen, embroidered with needlework; their pillars four,

and their sockets four. 17 All the posts around the courtyard are to
be banded with silver; their hooks are to be of silver and their bases
of bronze. 18 The length of the courtyard is to be about 150 feet, the
width about 75 feet throughout,[h] and the height about 7½ feet,[i] with
hangings of fine twisted linen and bases of bronze. 19 All the utensils
of the tabernacle for all its service, and all its tent pegs and all the
tent pegs of the courtyard, are to be of bronze.
20 "And you shall command the Israelites to bring you pure olive oil,
beaten, for the light, to make a lamp burn continually. 21 In the tent of
meeting,[j] outside the curtain that hangs before the testimony, Aaron
and his sons shall keep the lamp in order, from dusk until dawn,
before Yahweh. It shall be an everlasting statute for the Israelites,
throughout their generations.

Notes

- a (27:1) Hebrew "five cubits long and five cubits wide … three cubits high," about 2.3 meters square and 1.4 meters high.
- b (27:2) Projections shaped like horns at the corners of the altar, the holiest part of it (29:12).
- c (27:9) Hebrew "a hundred cubits," about 45 meters. So also in verses 11 and 18.
- d (27:10) Or "connecting rods."
- e (27:12) Hebrew "fifty cubits," about 23 meters. So also in verses 13 and 18.
- f (27:14) Hebrew "fifteen cubits," about 6.8 meters. So also in verse 15.
- g (27:16) Hebrew "twenty cubits," about 9 meters.
- h (27:18) Hebrew "fifty by fifty," which may mean fifty cubits at each end.
- i (27:18) Hebrew "five cubits," about 2.3 meters.
- j (27:21) Hebrew ohel mo'ed, the tent where Yahweh met with Moses and the people (29:42–43). It is another name for the tabernacle.

Chapter 28

1 "And bring near to you Aaron your brother, and his sons with him,
from among the Israelites, that he may minister to me as priest—
Aaron, Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar, Aaron's sons. 2 You
are to make holy garments for your brother Aaron, for glory and for
beauty. 3 And you shall speak to all who are wise of heart,[a] whom
I have filled with the spirit of wisdom, that they make Aaron's
garments to sanctify him, that he may minister to me as priest. 4
These are the garments that they shall make: a breastplate and an

ephod, a robe and a woven tunic, a turban and a sash. They shall make holy garments for Aaron your brother and for his sons, that he may minister to me as priest. 5 They are to use gold, blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine linen.

6 "They shall make the ephod of gold, blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen, artistically worked. 7 It shall have two shoulder straps joined to its two edges, so that it is joined together. 8 The skillfully woven band[b] on it, which is on it, is to be of the same workmanship and of one piece with it, of gold, of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and of fine twisted linen. 9 You are to take two onyx stones and engrave on them the names of the sons of Israel, 10 six of their names on one stone, and the names of the remaining six on the other stone, in the order of their birth. 11 As a jeweler engraves a seal, you are to engrave the two stones with the names of the sons of Israel. You are to set them in settings of gold filigree. 12 You are to put the two stones on the shoulder pieces of the ephod, as stones of remembrance for the sons of Israel. Aaron is to bear their names before Yahweh on his two shoulders for remembrance. 13 You are to make settings of gold filigree, 14 and two chains of pure gold, twisted like cords, and fasten the corded chains to the settings.

15 "You shall make the breastplate of judgment, artistically worked; like the work of the ephod you shall make it, with gold and with blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and with fine twisted linen. 16 It is to be square and folded double, about 9 inches long and about 9 inches wide.[c] 17 You are to set in it settings of stones, four rows of stones. A row of carnelian, topaz, and emerald[d] is to be the first row; 18 the second row a turquoise, a lapis lazuli, and a diamond;[e] 19 the third row a jacinth, an agate, and an amethyst; 20 and the fourth row a beryl, an onyx, and a jasper. They are to be set in gold filigree. 21 And the stones shall be twelve, corresponding to the names of the sons of Israel; they shall be engraved like a signet with each one's name, for the twelve tribes. 22 You are to make for the breastpiece twisted chains like cords, of pure gold. 23 You are to make for the breastpiece two rings of gold and put the two rings on the two ends of the breastpiece. 24 You are to put the two cords of gold in the two rings at the ends

of the breastpiece. 25 The other two ends of the two cords you are to
attach to the two settings, and so attach them to the shoulder pieces
of the ephod at the front. 26 You shall make two rings of gold, and
put them on the two ends of the breastplate, on its edge, which is
toward the ephod on the inside. 27 You are to make two rings of gold
and attach them to the lower part of the two shoulder pieces of the
ephod, on its front, near its seam, above the skillfully woven band of
the ephod. 28 They shall tie the breastplate by its rings to the rings of
the ephod with a blue cord, so that it is above the skillfully woven
band of the ephod, and the breastplate does not come loose from the
ephod. 29 So Aaron shall carry the names of the sons of Israel in the
breastplate of judgment upon his heart, when he goes into the Holy
Place, for a memorial continually before Yahweh. 30 In the breastpiece
of judgment you are to put the Urim and the Thummim,[f] and they are
to be over Aaron's heart when he goes in before Yahweh. So Aaron
is to bear the judgment of the Israelites over his heart before Yahweh
continually.
31 "You are to make the robe of the ephod all of blue. 32 In the middle
of it there shall be an opening for the head, and around its opening
there shall be a woven binding, like the opening of a coat of mail,[g]
so that it will not tear. 33 On its hem you are to make pomegranates
of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, around its hem, with bells of gold
between them all around: 34 a golden bell and a pomegranate, a golden
bell and a pomegranate, around the hem of the robe. 35 It is to be on
Aaron when he ministers, and its sound is to be heard when he goes
into the Holy Place before Yahweh and when he comes out, so that
he will not die.
36 "You are to make a plate[h] of pure gold and engrave on it, like the
engraving of a seal, 'Holy to Yahweh.' 37 You are to fasten it on the
turban by a cord of blue; it is to be on the front of the turban. 38 It
shall be upon the forehead of Aaron, that he may bear the iniquity
connected with the holy things which the Israelites hallow with all
their holy gifts; and it shall be on his forehead continually, that they
may find acceptance before Yahweh.

39 “You shall weave the tunic in checker work of fine linen, and you
shall make a turban of fine linen, and a sash of needlework. 40 For
Aaron’s sons you are to make tunics, sashes, and headbands; you are
to make them for glory and for beauty. 41 So you shall put them on
Aaron your brother and on his sons with him; and you shall anoint
them, consecrate them,[i] and sanctify them, that they may minister
to me as priests. 42 You are to make linen undergarments for them to
cover their naked flesh. They are to reach from the waist to the thighs.
43 They shall be on Aaron and on his sons whenever they enter the
tent of meeting, or approach the altar to minister in the Holy Place,
so that they do not bear iniquity and die. It shall be a statute forever
for him and for his descendants after him.

Notes

- a (28:3) Hebrew “wise of heart.” The Hebrew word hokhmah, “wisdom,” here means practical skill.
- b (28:8) Or “waistband,” a belt woven as part of the ephod.
- c (28:16) Hebrew “a span long and a span wide,” about 23 centimeters square. A span, the distance from thumb to little finger with the hand spread, was half a cubit, about 9 inches.
- d (28:17) The identification of several of these stones is uncertain; the English names follow the Septuagint and modern proposals. Compare the stones of the New Jerusalem in Revelation 21:19–20.
- e (28:18) Hebrew yahalom, perhaps a hard stone such as jasper or onyx. Diamonds were probably not cut in ancient Israel.
- f (28:30) The Urim and Thummim were objects kept in the breastpiece and used to learn God’s will (Numbers 27:21; 1 Samuel 28:6). Their form and use are uncertain. The words may mean “lights and perfections,” or they may begin with the first and last letters of the Hebrew alphabet.
- g (28:32) The meaning of the Hebrew word tahra is uncertain; it may mean a leather collar or the neck opening of a garment.
- h (28:36) Hebrew tsits, “flower” or “shining thing,” perhaps a rosette-shaped plate.
- i (28:41) Hebrew “fill their hand,” an expression for installing priests in office.

Chapter 29

1 “Now this is the thing you shall do to them to consecrate them, that
they may minister to me as priests: take one young bull and two rams
without blemish, 2 and unleavened bread, unleavened cakes mixed
with oil, and unleavened wafers spread with oil. You are to make them

of fine wheat flour. 3 And you shall put them into one basket, and bring
them in the basket, with the bull and the two rams. 4 You are to bring
Aaron and his sons to the entrance of the tent of meeting and wash
them with water. 5 You are to take the garments and put on Aaron
the tunic, the robe of the ephod, the ephod, and the breastpiece, and
tie the skillfully woven band of the ephod around him. 6 You are to
set the turban on his head and put the holy crown[a] on the turban. 7
You are to take the anointing oil, pour it on his head, and anoint him.
8 Then you are to bring his sons and put tunics on them. 9 You are
to tie sashes on them, Aaron and his sons, and bind headbands on
them. The priesthood is to be theirs by a statute forever. So you are
to ordain Aaron and his sons.
10 "You are to bring the bull before the tent of meeting. Aaron and
his sons are to lay their hands on the head of the bull. 11 Then you
are to slaughter the bull before Yahweh at the entrance of the tent of
meeting. 12 You are to take some of the blood of the bull and put it on
the horns of the altar with your finger, and you are to pour out all the
rest of the blood at the base of the altar. 13 You are to take all the fat
that covers the entrails, the lobe of the liver,[b] the two kidneys with
the fat that is on them, and burn them on the altar. 14 But the flesh of
the bull, together with its skin and its dung, you shall burn up with
fire outside the camp. It is a sin offering.[c]
15 "Then you are to take one of the rams, and Aaron and his sons are
to lay their hands on the head of the ram. 16 You are to slaughter the
ram, take its blood, and splash it against the altar on all sides. 17 You
are to cut the ram into its pieces, wash its entrails and its legs, and
put them with its pieces and its head. 18 You are to burn the whole
ram on the altar. It is a burnt offering to Yahweh, a pleasing aroma,
an offering by fire to Yahweh.
19 "You are to take the other ram, and Aaron and his sons are to lay
their hands on the head of the ram. 20 Then you shall kill the ram, and
take some of its blood and put it on the tip of the right ear of Aaron
and on the tips of the right ears of his sons, and on the thumbs of
their right hands and on the big toes of their right feet, and sprinkle
the blood all around on the altar. 21 And you shall take some of the

blood that is on the altar, and some of the anointing oil, and sprinkle it on Aaron and his garments, and on his sons and their garments with him; so he will be consecrated, and his garments, and his sons and their garments with him.
22 "You are to take the fat from the ram, the fat tail, the fat that covers the entrails, the lobe of the liver, the two kidneys with the fat that is on them, and the right thigh, for it is a ram of ordination; 23 and one loaf of bread, one cake of bread made with oil, and one wafer, out of the basket of unleavened bread that is before Yahweh. 24 And you shall put all these in the hands of Aaron and in the hands of his sons, and wave them as a wave offering[d] before Yahweh. 25 Then you are to take them from their hands and burn them on the altar on top of the burnt offering, as a pleasing aroma before Yahweh. It is an offering by fire to Yahweh.
26 "Then you shall take the breast from the ram of Aaron's consecration and wave it as a wave offering before Yahweh; and it shall be your portion. 27 You are to consecrate the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the contribution, which is waved and which is lifted up, from the ram of ordination, from what is Aaron's and from what is his sons'. 28 It shall be Aaron's and his sons' as a perpetual portion from the Israelites, for it is a contribution; it shall be an offering from the Israelites out of the sacrifices of their peace offerings,[e] their offering to Yahweh.
29 "The holy garments of Aaron are to belong to his sons after him, so that they may be anointed in them and ordained in them. 30 The son who becomes priest in his place, who comes into the tent of meeting to minister in the Holy Place, is to wear them seven days.
31 "You are to take the ram of ordination and boil its flesh in a holy place. 32 Aaron and his sons are to eat the flesh of the ram and the bread that is in the basket at the entrance of the tent of meeting. 33 They are to eat those things by which atonement was made, to ordain and consecrate them, but no outsider[f] may eat them, because they are holy. 34 If any of the flesh of the ordination or of the bread remains until the morning, you are to burn what remains with fire. It must not be eaten, because it is holy.

35 “So you are to do for Aaron and for his sons, according to all that I
have commanded you. Through seven days you are to ordain them.
36 And each day you shall offer a bull as a sin offering for atonement,
and you shall cleanse the altar when you make atonement for it, and
you shall anoint it to hallow it. 37 For seven days you are to make
atonement for the altar and consecrate it. Then the altar will be most
holy; whatever touches the altar will become holy.
38 “This is what you are to offer on the altar: two lambs a year old, day
by day, continually. 39 One lamb you shall offer in the morning, and the
other lamb you shall offer at twilight.[g] 40 With the first lamb there is
to be about 2 quarts of fine flour[h] mixed with about 1 quart of beaten
oil,[i] and about 1 quart of wine for a drink offering. 41 The other lamb
you are to offer at twilight, and offer with it a grain offering and its
drink offering as in the morning, for a pleasing aroma, an offering by
fire to Yahweh. 42 It is to be a continual burnt offering throughout your
generations at the entrance of the tent of meeting before Yahweh,
where I will meet with you, to speak to you there. 43 There I will meet
with the Israelites, and it will be made holy by my glory. 44 So I will
hallow the tent of meeting and the altar. I will also hallow both Aaron
and his sons to minister to me as priests. 45 I will dwell among the
Israelites and will be their God. 46 They will know that I am Yahweh
their God, who brought them out of the land of Egypt so that I might
dwell among them. I am Yahweh their God.

Notes

- a (29:6) That is, the gold plate inscribed “Holy to Yahweh” (28:36).
- b (29:13) Or “the appendage of the liver.” The exact organ is uncertain.
- c (29:14) Hebrew hatta’t, also translated “purification offering.”
- d (29:24) Hebrew tenufah, an offering presented by moving it toward the altar and back, or lifting it up.
- e (29:28) Hebrew shelamim, also translated “fellowship offerings” or “offerings of well-being.”
- f (29:33) Hebrew zar, a person not of the priestly family.
- g (29:39) Hebrew “between the two evenings,” understood either as between sunset and dark or as between midafternoon and sunset. So also in verse 41.
- h (29:40) Hebrew “a tenth,” meaning a tenth of an ephah, about 2.2 liters.
- i (29:40) Hebrew “a quarter of a hin,” about 0.9 liter. A hin was about 1 gallon (3.7 liters); estimates of ancient liquid measures vary.

Chapter 30

1 “You shall make an altar to burn incense on; of acacia wood you
shall make it. 2 It shall be about 18 inches long and 18 inches wide—
square—and about 3 feet high;[a] its horns shall be of one piece with
it. 3 You shall overlay it with pure gold—its top, its sides all around,
and its horns—and make a gold molding around it. 4 Two gold rings
you shall make for it, under its molding, on its two sides; you shall
make them on opposite sides, and they shall be holders for the poles
with which to carry it. 5 You are to make the poles of acacia wood
and overlay them with gold. 6 And you shall put it before the veil that
is by the ark of the testimony, before the mercy seat that is over the
testimony, where I will meet with you. 7 Aaron is to burn fragrant
incense on it. Every morning when he tends the lamps he is to burn
it, 8 and when Aaron sets up the lamps at twilight[b] he is to burn it,
a perpetual incense before Yahweh throughout your generations. 9
You must not offer unauthorized incense on it, or a burnt offering,
or a grain offering, and you must not pour a drink offering on it. 10
Aaron shall make atonement upon its horns once in the year; with
the blood of the sin offering of atonement he shall make atonement
upon it, once in the year throughout your generations. It is most holy
to Yahweh.”
11 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 12 “When you take a census of the
Israelites to count them, each man is to give a ransom for his life to
Yahweh when you count them, so that there may be no plague among
them when you count them. 13 Everyone who is counted is to give
this: a fifth of an ounce of silver,[c] by the sanctuary standard. This
is the offering to Yahweh. 14 Everyone who is counted, from twenty
years old and upward, is to give the offering to Yahweh. 15 The rich
shall not give more, and the poor shall not give less, than a fifth of an
ounce, when they give the offering of Yahweh to make atonement for
your lives. 16 And you shall take the atonement money of the Israelites
and appoint it for the service of the tent of meeting, that it may be
a memorial for the Israelites before Yahweh, to make atonement for
your lives.”

17 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 18 "You shall also make a basin of
bronze, with a stand of bronze, for washing. Set it between the tent
of meeting and the altar, and put water in it. 19 Aaron and his sons are
to wash their hands and their feet in it. 20 When they go into the tent
of meeting, they shall wash with water, lest they die; or when they
come near the altar to minister, by presenting an offering made by
fire to Yahweh, 21 they are to wash their hands and their feet, so that
they will not die. It is to be a statute forever for them, for him and his
descendants throughout their generations."
22 Moreover, Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 23 "Take for yourself
the finest spices: of liquid myrrh about 12½ pounds,[d] of fragrant
cinnamon half as much, about 6¼ pounds,[e] of fragrant cane[f] about
6¼ pounds, 24 of cassia about 12½ pounds, by the sanctuary standard,[g]
and about a gallon of olive oil.[h] 25 You are to make from these a holy
anointing oil, a fragrant blend, the work of a perfumer. It is to be a
holy anointing oil. 26 With it you are to anoint the tent of meeting,
the ark of the testimony, 27 the table and all its utensils, the lampstand
and its utensils, the altar of incense, 28 the altar of burnt offering with
all its utensils, and the basin and its stand. 29 You are to consecrate
them, so that they may be most holy. Whatever touches them will
become holy. 30 You are to anoint Aaron and his sons, and consecrate
them, so that they may serve me as priests. 31 You are to speak to the
Israelites, saying, 'This is to be a holy anointing oil to me throughout
your generations. 32 It must not be poured on anyone's body,[i] and you
must not make any like it with the same formula. It is holy, and it is
to be holy to you. 33 Whoever blends any like it, or whoever puts any
of it on an outsider, is to be cut off from his people.'"
34 Yahweh said to Moses, "Take for yourself sweet spices, stacte,[j]
onycha, and galbanum, sweet spices with pure frankincense, of each
an equal part. 35 You are to make from it incense, a blend, the work
of a perfumer, seasoned with salt, pure and holy. 36 You shall grind
part of it into fine powder and set some before the testimony in the
tent of meeting, where I will meet with you. It shall be most holy
to you. 37 The incense that you make according to its formula, you
must not make for yourselves. It is to be holy to you for Yahweh. 38

Whoever makes any like it, to enjoy its fragrance, is to be cut off from his people."

Notes

- a (30:2) Hebrew "a cubit long and a cubit wide ... two cubits high," about 45 centimeters square and 90 centimeters high.
- b (30:8) Hebrew "between the two evenings." See the note at 12:6.
- c (30:13) Hebrew "half a shekel according to the shekel of the sanctuary (the shekel is twenty gerahs)," about 5.7 grams. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams) and a gerah one-twentieth of a shekel. The "sanctuary shekel" may have been a standard kept at the sanctuary, or a heavier shekel; weights varied over time. In verse 15, Hebrew "half a shekel."
- d (30:23) Hebrew "five hundred shekels," about 5.75 kilograms. So also for the cassia in verse 24.
- e (30:23) Hebrew "two hundred fifty shekels," about 2.9 kilograms. So also for the cane.
- f (30:23) Or "calamus," an aromatic reed. The identification of several of these spices is uncertain.
- g (30:24) Hebrew "by the shekel of the sanctuary." See the note at verse 13.
- h (30:24) Hebrew "a hin of olive oil," about 3.7 liters.
- i (30:32) Hebrew "on the flesh of man," that is, on ordinary people.
- j (30:34) The identity of stacte (Hebrew nataf, "drops"), onycha (Hebrew shehelet, perhaps from a shellfish), and galbanum (a plant resin) is not certain.

Chapter 31

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "See, I have called by name Bezalel[a]
son of Uri, son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah. 3 and I have filled him
with the Spirit of God, in wisdom, in understanding, in knowledge,
and in every kind of workmanship, 4 to devise artistic designs, to
work in gold, in silver, and in bronze, 5 in cutting jewels for setting,
in carving wood, and in every kind of workmanship. 6 And I, look,
I have appointed with him Oholiab[b] son of Ahisamach, of the tribe
of Dan. And in the hearts of all who are skilled I have put skill, so
that they may make all that I have commanded you: 7 the tent of
meeting, and the ark of the testimony, and the mercy seat that is upon
it, and all the furniture of the tent— 8 the table and its utensils, the
pure lampstand with all its utensils, the altar of incense, 9 the altar of
burnt offering with all its utensils, the basin and its stand, 10 the finely
woven[c] garments, the holy garments for Aaron the priest and the

garments of his sons, for their service as priests, [11] the anointing oil, and the fragrant incense for the Holy Place. They are to do according to all that I have commanded you."
[12] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [13] "Speak to the Israelites and say, 'Above all you are to keep my Sabbaths, for this is a sign between me and you throughout your generations, so that you may know that I am Yahweh who makes you holy.[d] [14] You shall keep the Sabbath, because it is holy to you. Everyone who profanes it shall surely be put to death; anyone who does work on it, that soul shall be cut off from among his people. [15] Six days work may be done, but the seventh day is a Sabbath of complete rest,[e] holy to Yahweh. Whoever does any work on the Sabbath day must be put to death. [16] So the Israelites are to keep the Sabbath, observing the Sabbath throughout their generations as a perpetual covenant. [17] It is a sign between me and the Israelites forever, for in six days Yahweh made the heavens and the earth, and on the seventh day he rested and was refreshed.'"
[18] When he had finished speaking with him on Mount Sinai, he gave to Moses the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone inscribed by the finger of God.

Notes

- a (31:2) Bezalel means "in the shadow (protection) of God."
- b (31:6) Oholiab means "the father is my tent."
- c (31:10) Or "the woven," or "the service." The meaning of the Hebrew word serad is uncertain.
- d (31:13) Hebrew YHWH meqaddishkem, "Yahweh who sanctifies you." Compare Leviticus 20:8.
- e (31:15) Hebrew shabbat shabbaton, "a Sabbath of Sabbath rest."

Chapter 32

[1] When the people saw that Moses was slow to come down from the mountain, the people assembled before Aaron and said to him, "Rise up, make us gods[a] that shall go before us; for as for this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him." [2] Aaron said to them, "Take off the gold rings that are in the ears of your wives, your sons, and your daughters, and bring them to me." [3] So all the people tore off the gold

rings that were in their ears and brought them to Aaron. 4 He received
the gold from their hand, fashioned it with an engraving tool,[b] and
made it into a cast-metal calf. And they said, "These are your gods,
Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!" 5 When Aaron
saw it, he built an altar before it; and Aaron made a proclamation and
said, "Tomorrow is a feast to Yahweh." 6 They rose early on the next
day, and offered burnt offerings and brought peace offerings; and the
people sat down to eat and drink, and rose up to play.[c]
7 Yahweh said to Moses, "Go, get down, for your people, whom you
brought up out of the land of Egypt, have acted corruptly. 8 They have
quickly turned aside from the way I commanded them. They have
made for themselves a calf of molten metal, and have bowed down
to it and sacrificed to it, saying, 'These are your gods, Israel, who
brought you up out of the land of Egypt!'" 9 Yahweh said to Moses,
"I have seen this people, and look, it is a stiff-necked people. 10 Now
therefore leave me alone, so that my anger may burn against them
and I may consume them; and I will make of you a great nation."
11 But Moses implored Yahweh his God and said, "Yahweh, why does
your anger burn against your people, whom you have brought out of
the land of Egypt with great power and with a mighty hand? 12 Why
should the Egyptians say, 'With harmful intent did he bring them out,
to slay them among the mountains and to blot them from the surface
of the earth'? Turn from your fierce anger, and relent[d] concerning
this evil against your people. 13 Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel,
your servants, to whom you swore by your own self and declared, 'I
will make your descendants multiply like the stars of heaven, and all
this land that I have spoken of I will give to your descendants, and
they shall inherit it forever.'" 14 And Yahweh relented from the harm
that he had said he would do to his people.
15 Moses turned and went down from the mountain, the two tablets
of the testimony in his hand, tablets written on both their sides; on
the one side and on the other they were written. 16 The tablets were
the work of God, and the writing was the writing of God, engraved
on the tablets. 17 When Joshua heard the noise of the people as they
shouted, he said to Moses, "There is a sound of war in the camp." 18

But he said, "It is not the voice of those who shout for victory, nor the voice of those who cry in defeat; the voice of singing[e] I hear."
19 As soon as he came near the camp and saw the calf and the dancing, Moses' anger blazed hot, and he cast the tablets from his hands and shattered them at the base of the mountain. 20 He took the calf that they had made, burned it with fire, ground it to powder, scattered it on the water, and made the Israelites drink it.
21 Moses said to Aaron, "What did this people do to you, that you have brought so great a sin on them?" 22 Aaron said, "Do not let the anger of my lord burn. You know the people, that they are set on evil. 23 For they said to me, 'Make us gods who will go before us. As for this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him.' 24 So I said to them, 'Whoever has any gold, take it off.' So they gave it to me, and I threw it into the fire, and out came this calf."
25 Moses saw that the people were out of control—for Aaron had let them get out of control, to be a laughingstock among their adversaries — 26 then Moses stood in the entrance of the camp and said, "Who is on Yahweh's side? Let him come to me." And all the sons of Levi gathered themselves to him. 27 He said to them, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'Let every man put his sword on his thigh and go to and fro, from gate to gate throughout the camp, and let every man slay his brother, his friend, and his neighbor.'" 28 The sons of Levi did according to the word of Moses. About three thousand men of the people fell that day. 29 Moses said, "Ordain yourselves[f] today for Yahweh, each one at the cost of his son and his brother, so that he may give you a blessing this day."
30 The next day Moses said to the people, "You have sinned a great sin. And now I will go up to Yahweh; perhaps I can make atonement for your sin." 31 So Moses returned to Yahweh and said, "Alas, this people has sinned a great sin. They have made themselves gods of gold. 32 But now, if you will forgive their sin… But if not, please blot me out of your book that you have written." 33 But Yahweh said to Moses, "Whoever has sinned against me, him I will blot out of my book. 34 But now go, lead the people to the place of which I spoke to you. See,

my angel shall go before you; nevertheless, in the day when I visit, I will bring their sin upon them." 35 Then Yahweh struck the people with a plague, because they made the calf, the one that Aaron made.

Notes

- a (32:1) Or "a god." Hebrew elohim with a plural verb; the same form is used in verses 4, 8, and 23. Compare 1 Kings 12:28.
- b (32:4) Or "bound it in a bag." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (32:6) The Hebrew verb tsahaq can include revelry or sexual play. Compare 1 Corinthians 10:7.
- d (32:12) Or "change your mind." Hebrew niham, used also in verse 14.
- e (32:18) Hebrew "of answering," perhaps singing in response, or antiphonal singing. The Septuagint reads "of those who begin a song over wine."
- f (32:29) Hebrew "Fill your hands," the expression for ordination to priestly service (28:41). The Samaritan Pentateuch, Septuagint, and Vulgate read, "You have ordained yourselves."

Chapter 33

1 Yahweh said to Moses, "Go, set out from here, you and the people whom you brought up from the land of Egypt, to the land of which I swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob, saying, 'To your offspring I will give it.' 2 I will send an angel before you, and I will drive out the Canaanites, the Amorites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites. 3 Go up to a land flowing with milk and honey. But I will not go up among you, for you are a stiff-necked people, or I might consume you on the way."

4 When the people heard this harsh word, they mourned, and no one put on his ornaments. 5 For Yahweh had said to Moses, "Tell the Israelites, 'You are a stubborn people. If I should go up among you even for a moment, I would consume you. So now take your ornaments off, and I will decide what to do with you.'" 6 So the Israelites stripped themselves of their ornaments from Mount Horeb onward.

7 Now Moses used to take the tent and pitch it outside the camp, at a distance from the camp, and he called it the tent of meeting.[a] And everyone who sought Yahweh went out to the tent of meeting that was outside the camp. 8 Whenever Moses went out to the tent, all the people would rise and stand, each at the entrance of his own tent, and watch Moses until he had gone into the tent. 9 Whenever Moses

entered the tent, the pillar of cloud would come down and stand at the entrance of the tent, and Yahweh[b] would speak with Moses. 10 When all the people saw the pillar of cloud standing at the entrance of the tent, all the people would rise and bow down, each at the entrance of his own tent. 11 Yahweh would speak to Moses face to face, as one speaks to a friend. When Moses returned to the camp, his young assistant, Joshua son of Nun,[c] would not leave the tent.

12 Moses said to Yahweh, "See, you say to me, 'Bring up this people,' but you have not let me know whom you will send with me. Yet you have said, 'I know you by name, and you have also found favor in my sight.' 13 Now, if I have found favor in your eyes, show me now your ways, that I may know you and find favor in your eyes. And consider that this nation is your people." 14 He said, "My presence[d] will go with you, and I will give you rest." 15 He said to him, "If your presence does not go with us, do not carry us up from here. 16 For how shall it be known that I and your people have found favor in your eyes? Is it not by your going with us, so that we, I and your people, are set apart from all the peoples on the face of the earth?"

17 Yahweh said to Moses, "I will do this very thing also that you have spoken, for you have found favor in my eyes, and I know you by name." 18 Moses said, "Please show me your glory." 19 And he said, "I will make all my goodness pass before you, and I will proclaim the name Yahweh before you.[e] I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious, and I will show mercy to whom I will show mercy."[f] 20 But he said, "You cannot see my face, for no human being may see me and live." 21 Yahweh said, "See, there is a place beside me, where you shall stand upon the rock; 22 While my glory passes by, I will put you in a cleft of the rock and cover you with my hand until I have passed by. 23 Then I will take away my hand, and you will see my back,[g] but my face must not be seen."

Notes

- a (33:7) Here the "tent of meeting" is a tent pitched outside the camp before the tabernacle was built (compare chapters 35–40).
- b (33:9) Hebrew "he."
- c (33:11) Joshua is called "son of Nun" here for the first time. Nun means "fish."

- d (33:14) Hebrew "my face," so also in verse 15 ("your face"). The Septuagint reads "I myself will go before you."
- e (33:19) Or "I will proclaim my name, 'Yahweh,' before you." See 34:5–7.
- f (33:19) Paul quotes these words in Romans 9:15.
- g (33:23) Or "my aftermath," what remains after I have passed. The Hebrew is unusual and the language is deliberately reserved.

Chapter 34

1 Yahweh said to Moses, "Cut two tablets of stone like the first ones,
and I will write on the tablets the words that were on the first tablets,
which you broke. 2 Be ready by morning, and come up in the morning
to Mount Sinai, and present yourself there to me on the top of the
mountain. 3 No one shall come up with you, nor let anyone be seen
anywhere on the mountain; neither let the flocks or herds feed in
front of that mountain." 4 So Moses cut two tablets of stone like the
first ones. He rose early in the morning and went up Mount Sinai, as
Yahweh had commanded him, and took in his hand the two tablets
of stone.
5 Yahweh came down in the cloud and stood with him there, and
he proclaimed the name Yahweh.[a] 6 Yahweh passed before him and
proclaimed, "Yahweh, Yahweh,[b] a God compassionate and gracious,[c]
slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love[d] and faithfulness,[e] 7
keeping steadfast love for thousands,[f] forgiving iniquity, transgres-
sion, and sin; yet who will by no means acquit the guilty, but visits
the iniquity of fathers on children, and on grandchildren, to the third
and the fourth generation."
8 Moses quickly bowed his head toward the ground and worshiped.
9 He said, "If now I have found favor in your sight, Lord,[g] please let
the Lord go in our midst, for it is a stiff-necked people. Pardon our
iniquity and our sin, and take us for your inheritance."
10 And he said, "See, I am making a covenant. Before all your people
I will do marvels, such as have never been wrought in all the earth
or among any nation; and all the people in whose midst you are shall
see the work of Yahweh, for it is an awesome thing that I will do
with you. 11 Keep what I command you today. Look, I am driving out
before you the Amorites, the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Perizzites,

the Hivites, and the Jebusites. 12 Be careful not to make a covenant
with the inhabitants of the land to which you are going, or it will
become a snare among you. 13 But you shall demolish their altars,
smash their pillars, and cut down their Asherim.[h] 14 For you are not
to bow down to any other god, for Yahweh, whose name is Jealous,[i]
is a jealous God. 15 Take care that you make no covenant with the
inhabitants of the land, lest they play the harlot after their gods and
sacrifice to their gods, and someone invite you, and you eat of his
sacrifice, 16 and you will take some of their daughters for your sons,
and their daughters will prostitute themselves after their gods and
make your sons prostitute themselves after their gods. 17 You are not
to make for yourselves gods of cast metal.
18 "You are to keep the Feast of Unleavened Bread. Seven days you are
to eat unleavened bread, as I commanded you, at the appointed time
in the month of Abib (March–April),[j] for in the month of Abib you
came out of Egypt. 19 Every firstborn[k] belongs to me, all your male
livestock, the firstborn of cattle and sheep. 20 The firstborn of a donkey
you shall redeem with a lamb; and if you do not redeem it, then you
shall break its neck. All the firstborn of your sons you shall redeem.
None shall appear before me empty.
21 "Six days you shall work, but on the seventh day you shall rest;
in plowing time and in harvest you shall rest. 22 And you shall keep
the Feast of Weeks,[l] the firstfruits of the wheat harvest, and the Feast
of Ingathering at the year's end. 23 Three times in the year all your
males are to appear before the Lord Yahweh, the God of Israel.[m] 24 For
I will cast out nations before you and widen your borders; neither
shall any man desire your land when you go up three times in the
year to appear before Yahweh your God.
25 "You are not to offer the blood of my sacrifice with anything
leavened, and the sacrifice of the Feast of the Passover is not to be
left until the morning. 26 The best of the firstfruits of your ground you
are to bring to the house of Yahweh your God. You are not to boil a
young goat in its mother's milk."[n]
27 Yahweh said to Moses, "Write these words, for in accordance with
these words I have made a covenant with you and with Israel." 28 So

he was there with Yahweh forty days and forty nights. He neither ate bread nor drank water. And he[o] wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant, the Ten Words.[p]

29 When Moses came down from Mount Sinai, the two tablets of the testimony being in Moses' hand as he came down from the mountain, Moses did not know that the skin of his face shone[q] because he had spoken with him.[r] 30 When Aaron and all the Israelites saw Moses, the skin of his face shone, and they were afraid to come near him. 31 But Moses called to them, and Aaron and all the leaders of the congregation returned to him, and Moses talked with them. 32 Afterward all the Israelites came near, and he commanded them all that Yahweh had spoken with him on Mount Sinai. 33 When Moses had finished speaking with them, he put a veil over his face. 34 Whenever Moses went in before Yahweh to speak with him, he would remove the veil until he came out. And when he came out and told the Israelites what he had been commanded, 35 the Israelites saw that the skin of Moses' face shone; and Moses would put the veil on his face again, until he went in to speak with him.

Notes

- a (34:5) Or "he called on the name of Yahweh." The subject may be Yahweh or Moses.
- b (34:6) These words (verses 6–7) are Yahweh's own declaration of his character, the fullest self-description in the Old Testament. They are echoed again and again: Numbers 14:18; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalms 86:15; 103:8; 145:8; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2; Nahum 1:3. Grammatically the first words may also be read, "Yahweh, Yahweh is a God compassionate…."
- c (34:6) Hebrew el rahum vehannun. Rahum, "compassionate," is related to rehem, "womb," suggesting a mother's tender love; hannun, "gracious," describes favor freely given.
- d (34:6) Hebrew hesed, the loyal, committed love that keeps covenant. See the note at 15:13.
- e (34:6) Hebrew emet, "truth," "reliability," "faithfulness."
- f (34:7) Or "to the thousandth generation" (compare Deuteronomy 7:9). The contrast with "the third and the fourth generation" stresses that God's mercy far outweighs his judgment.
- g (34:9) Hebrew Adonai, "my Lord." Some Hebrew manuscripts read "Yahweh."
- h (34:13) Hebrew asherim, wooden poles or images associated with the goddess Asherah.

- i (34:14) Hebrew Qanna. On God's jealousy, see the note at 20:5. Here "Jealous" is presented as a name, expressing his exclusive claim on his people.
- j (34:18) Hebrew "the month of Abib." See the note at 13:4.
- k (34:19) Hebrew "everything that opens the womb."
- l (34:22) Hebrew shavu'ot, later called Pentecost ("fiftieth"), because it came seven weeks (fifty days) after Passover.
- m (34:23) Hebrew ha'adon YHWH elohe yisra'el, "the Lord Yahweh, the God of Israel." On ha'adon see the note at 23:17.
- n (34:26) See the note at 23:19.
- o (34:28) The context suggests that Yahweh is the one who wrote (verse 1; Deuteronomy 10:2–4), though grammatically the subject could be Moses (verse 27).
- p (34:28) Hebrew "the ten words," the source of the term "Decalogue." Compare Deuteronomy 4:13; 10:4.
- q (34:29) Hebrew qaran, related to qeren, "horn." The verb probably means "sent out rays." The Latin Vulgate rendered it cornuta, "horned," which led to medieval and Renaissance art (including Michelangelo's statue) showing Moses with horns. The Septuagint reads "was glorified." Compare 2 Corinthians 3:7–18.
- r (34:29) That is, with Yahweh.

Chapter 35

1 Moses gathered all the assembly of the Israelites and said to them,
"These are the things which Yahweh has commanded you to do:[a] 2
For six days work shall be done, but the seventh day shall be holy to
you, a Sabbath of complete rest to Yahweh; whoever works on that
day shall be put to death. 3 You shall kindle no fire throughout your
habitations on the Sabbath day."
4 And Moses spoke to all the assembly of the Israelites, saying, "This
is what Yahweh has commanded: 5 Take from among you an offering
for Yahweh. Whoever has a willing heart, let him bring it as Yahweh's
offering: gold, silver, and bronze; 6 blue, purple, and scarlet yarn,
fine linen, and goats' hair; 7 rams' skins dyed red, fine leather, and
acacia wood; 8 oil for the light, spices for the anointing oil and for the
fragrant incense; 9 onyx stones and stones to be set, for the ephod and
for the breastpiece.
10 "Let every skilled person among you come and make all that
Yahweh has commanded: 11 the tabernacle, its tent and its covering,
its clasps and its frames, its crossbars, its posts, and its bases; 12 the ark
and its poles, the atonement cover, and the veil of the screen; 13 the

table and its poles and all its utensils, and the bread of the Presence;
14 the lampstand also for the light, with its utensils, its lamps, and the
oil for the light; 15 the altar of incense with its poles, the anointing oil,
the sweet incense, and the hanging for the door at the entrance of
the tabernacle; 16 the altar of burnt offering with its grating of bronze,
its poles, and all its utensils, the basin and its stand; 17 the hangings
of the court, with its pillars and its sockets, and the hanging for the
gate of the court; 18 the tent pegs of the tabernacle and the tent pegs
of the courtyard, and their cords; 19 the finely woven garments for
ministering in the Holy Place, the holy garments for Aaron the priest,
and the garments of his sons, for their service as priests."
20 Then all the congregation of the Israelites departed from the
presence of Moses. 21 And they came, everyone whose heart stirred
him, and everyone whose spirit moved him, and brought Yahweh's
offering for the work of the tent of meeting, for all its service, and
for the holy garments. 22 They came, both men and women, all who
had a willing heart, and brought brooches, earrings, signet rings, and
necklaces,[b] all sorts of gold objects, everyone presenting an offering
of gold to Yahweh. 23 Every man with whom was found blue, purple,
or scarlet yarn, fine linen, goats' hair, or fine leather, or rams' skins
dyed red, brought it. 24 Everyone who could make an offering of silver
or bronze brought it as Yahweh's offering, and everyone who had
acacia wood for any work of the service brought it. 25 All the women
who were wise of heart spun with their hands, and brought what
they had spun: blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine linen. 26 All the
women whose hearts stirred them with skill spun the goats' hair. 27
The leaders brought onyx stones and stones to be set, for the ephod
and for the breastpiece, 28 and the spices and the oil for the light, for
the anointing oil, and for the fragrant incense. 29 All the men and
women of the Israelites whose heart moved them to bring anything
for all the work that Yahweh had commanded through Moses to be
done brought it as a freewill offering to Yahweh.
30 Then Moses said to the Israelites, "See, Yahweh has called by name
Bezalel son of Uri, son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah. 31 and he has filled
him with the Spirit of God, in wisdom, in understanding, in knowl-

edge, and in all kinds of workmanship, 32 to devise artistic designs, to
work in gold, in silver, and in bronze, 33 in cutting jewels for setting, in
carving wood, for making any kind of skilled work. 34 And he has put
it in his heart to teach, both he and Oholiab son of Ahisamach, of the
tribe of Dan. 35 He has filled them with wisdom of heart to do every
sort of work of the engraver, and of the skilled designer, and of the
embroiderer in blue, purple, and scarlet yarn and in fine linen, and of
the weaver—they do every work, and they devise skillful designs.

Notes

- a (35:1) Chapters 35–40 report how the instructions of chapters 25–31 were carried out, repeating them almost word for word. In the Septuagint these chapters are shorter and arranged in a different order: for example, the priestly garments (Hebrew 39) come before the tabernacle structure (Hebrew 36), the making of the incense altar (Hebrew 37:25–28) is not reported, and several sections are abbreviated. In Brenton's English edition the chapters are numbered differently, so that the curtains appear in chapter 37 and the ark in chapter 38. Scholars debate whether the Greek translator abridged and rearranged the Hebrew or worked from a different Hebrew edition. This translation follows the Hebrew order.
- b (35:22) Or "pendants." The identity of some of these ornaments is uncertain.

Chapter 36

1 "Bezalel and Oholiab and every skilled person in whom Yahweh has
put skill and understanding to know how to do all the work for the
service of the sanctuary are to work according to all that Yahweh has
commanded."
2 Then Moses called Bezalel and Oholiab and every wise-hearted man
in whose heart Yahweh had put wisdom, everyone whose heart was
stirred up to come to the work to do it. 3 They received from Moses
all the offering that the Israelites had brought for the work of the
service of the sanctuary, to make it. They kept bringing him freewill
offerings every morning, 4 so all the wise men who were doing every
work of the sanctuary came, each from his own work which he was
doing, 5 and said to Moses, "The people are bringing much more than
enough for the service of the work that Yahweh has commanded us
to do." 6 So Moses gave a command, and they proclaimed throughout
the camp: "Neither man nor woman is to make any further work for
the offering of the sanctuary." Thus the people were restrained from

bringing. 7 for the material they had was sufficient for all the work to be done, and more than enough.

8 Every wise-hearted man among those who did the work made the tabernacle with ten curtains of fine twisted linen and blue, purple, and scarlet yarn; with cherubim, the work of a skilled designer, he made them. 9 The length of each curtain was about 42 feet, and the width of each curtain about 6 feet;[a] all the curtains had the same measurements. 10 He[b] joined five curtains to one another, and the other five curtains he joined to one another. 11 And he made loops of blue on the edge of one curtain at the end of the first set; so also he made them on the edge of the outermost curtain of the second set. 12 He made fifty loops on the one curtain, and he made fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that was in the second set. The loops were opposite one another. 13 And he made fifty hooks of gold and coupled the curtains to one another with the hooks, so that it became one tabernacle.

14 He also made curtains of goats' hair for a tent over the tabernacle; he made eleven curtains. 15 The length of each curtain was about 45 feet, and the width of each curtain about 6 feet;[c] the eleven curtains had the same measurements. 16 He joined five curtains by themselves and six curtains by themselves. 17 And he made fifty loops on the edge of the last curtain of the first set, and fifty loops on the edge of the curtain of the second set. 18 He made fifty clasps of bronze to join the tent together, so that it might be a single whole. 19 He made for the tent a covering of rams' skins dyed red, and a covering of fine leather above that.

20 He made the upright frames for the tabernacle of acacia wood. 21 The length of a frame was about 15 feet, and the width of each frame about 2¼ feet.[d] 22 Each frame had two tenons for joining them together. He did this for all the frames of the tabernacle. 23 He made the frames for the tabernacle: twenty frames for the south side. 24 And forty sockets of silver he made under the twenty boards: two sockets under the one board for its two tenons, and two sockets under the next board for its two tenons. 25 For the second side of the tabernacle, on the north side, he made twenty frames 26 and their forty sockets of silver: two sockets under the one board, and two sockets under the next board. 27 And for

the rear of the tabernacle toward the west he made six boards. 28 He made two frames for the corners of the tabernacle at the rear. 29 They were doubled at the bottom and likewise complete at the top, up to the first ring. He made both of them this way for the two corners. 30 So there were eight boards, and their sockets were of silver, sixteen sockets—under each board two sockets.

31 And he made bars of acacia wood: five for the boards of the one side of the tabernacle, 32 five bars for the boards of the other side of the tabernacle, and five bars for the boards of the tabernacle at the rear toward the west. 33 He made the middle crossbar to run halfway up the frames from end to end. 34 He overlaid the frames with gold and made their rings of gold as holders for the crossbars, and he overlaid the crossbars with gold.

35 He made the veil of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn and fine twisted linen; with cherubim, skillfully worked, he made it. 36 He made four posts of acacia for it and overlaid them with gold. Their hooks were of gold, and he cast for them four bases of silver. 37 He also made a hanging for the door of the tent, embroidered with needlework, of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen, 38 and its five posts with their hooks. He overlaid their tops and their bands with gold, and their five bases were of bronze.

Notes

- a (36:9) Hebrew "twenty-eight cubits" and "four cubits," about 12.6 by 1.8 meters. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters); see the note at 25:10.
- b (36:10) That is, Bezalel (37:1), with those who worked under him.
- c (36:15) Hebrew "thirty cubits" and "four cubits," about 13.5 by 1.8 meters.
- d (36:21) Hebrew "ten cubits" and "a cubit and a half," about 4.5 by 0.7 meters.

Chapter 37

1 Bezalel made the ark of acacia wood, about 3¾ feet long, 2¼ feet wide, and 2¼ feet high.[a] 2 He overlaid it with pure gold inside and outside, and made a molding of gold around it. 3 He cast for it four rings of gold for its four feet, two rings on one side of it and two rings on the other side. 4 He made poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with gold, 5 and put the poles into the rings on the sides of the ark, to carry the ark.

6 He made an atonement cover of pure gold, about 3¾ feet long and
2¼ feet wide.[b] 7 He made two cherubim of gold; he made them of
hammered work at the two ends of the atonement cover, 8 one cherub
at one end and one cherub at the other end. He made the cherubim of
one piece with the atonement cover at its two ends. 9 The cherubim
spread out their wings above, overshadowing the atonement cover
with their wings, with their faces toward one another; the faces of
the cherubim were toward the atonement cover.
10 He made the table of acacia wood, about 3 feet long, 1½ feet wide,
and 2¼ feet high.[c] 11 He overlaid it with pure gold and made a molding
of gold around it. 12 He made a rim around it about 3 inches wide,[d]
and made a molding of gold around the rim. 13 He cast four rings of
gold for it and fastened the rings at the four corners at its four legs.
14 Close to the rim were the rings, as places for the poles to carry the
table. 15 And he made the poles of acacia wood for carrying the table,
and overlaid them with gold. 16 He made the utensils that were on the
table, its plates and its dishes, its bowls and its jars for pouring out
drink offerings, of pure gold.
17 He made the lampstand of pure gold, making it of hammered work;
its base and its stem, its cups, its knobs, and its flowers were of one
piece with it. 18 Six branches went out from its sides, three branches of
the lampstand from one side of it and three branches of the lampstand
from the other side of it. 19 There were three cups shaped like almond
blossoms on one branch, each with a knob and a flower, and three
cups shaped like almond blossoms on the next branch, each with a
knob and a flower; so for the six branches going out from the lamp-
stand. 20 On the lampstand itself were four cups shaped like almond
blossoms, with their knobs and flowers, 21 and a knob under the first
pair of branches, of one piece with it, and a knob under the second
pair of branches, of one piece with it, and a knob under the third pair
of branches, of one piece with it, for the six branches going out from
it. 22 Their knobs and their branches were of one piece with it; all of it
was one hammered piece of pure gold. 23 He made its seven lamps, its
snuffers, and its trays of pure gold. 24 He made it and all its utensils
from about 75 pounds of pure gold.[e]

25 He made the altar of incense of acacia wood. It was about 18 inches
long and 18 inches wide, square, and about 3 feet high.[f] Its horns were
of one piece with it. 26 He overlaid it with pure gold, its top, its sides
all around, and its horns, and he made a molding of gold around it.
27 And he made two gold rings for it below its molding, on opposite
sides of it, as places for the poles with which to carry it. 28 He made
the poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with gold.
29 He made the holy anointing oil and the pure fragrant incense, the
work of a perfumer.

Notes

- a (37:1) Hebrew "two and a half cubits long, a cubit and a half wide, and a cubit and a half high," about 1.1 by 0.7 by 0.7 meters. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters); see the note at 25:10.
- b (37:6) Hebrew "two and a half cubits long and a cubit and a half wide," about 1.1 by 0.7 meters.
- c (37:10) Hebrew "two cubits long, a cubit wide, and a cubit and a half high," about 90 by 45 by 70 centimeters.
- d (37:12) Hebrew "a handbreadth," about 3 inches (7.5 centimeters).
- e (37:24) Hebrew "a talent of pure gold," about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- f (37:25) Hebrew "a cubit long and a cubit wide ... two cubits high," about 45 centimeters square and 90 centimeters high.

Chapter 38

1 He made the altar of burnt offering of acacia wood, about 7½ feet
long and 7½ feet wide. It was square, and about 4½ feet high.[a] 2 He
made its horns on its four corners; its horns were of one piece with
it, and he overlaid it with bronze. 3 He made all the utensils of the
altar, the pots, the shovels, the basins, the forks, and the firepans; he
made all its utensils of bronze. 4 And he made for the altar a grating
of bronze network, beneath its ledge, reaching halfway up. 5 He cast
four rings for the four corners of the bronze grating, to be places for
the poles. 6 He made the poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with
bronze. 7 And he put the poles into the rings on the sides of the altar,
with which to carry it; he made it hollow, with planks.
8 He made the laver of bronze, with its base of bronze, from the bronze
mirrors[b] of the women who ministered[c] at the door of the tent of
meeting.

9 Then he made the court. On the south side, toward the south, the
hangings of the court were of fine twisted linen, about 150 feet in
length;[d] 10 with their twenty posts and their twenty bases of bronze;
the hooks of the posts and their bands were of silver. 11 For the north
side there were hangings about 150 feet long, with their twenty posts
and their twenty bases of bronze; the hooks of the posts and their
bands were of silver. 12 For the west side there were hangings about 75
feet long,[e] with their ten posts and their ten bases; the hooks of the
posts and their bands were of silver. 13 For the front, to the east, about
75 feet. 14 The hangings for one side of the entrance were about 22½
feet long,[f] with their three posts and their three bases. 15 So also for the
other side; on both sides of the gate of the courtyard were hangings
about 22½ feet long, with their three posts and their three bases. 16 All
the hangings around the courtyard were of fine twisted linen. 17 The
bases for the posts were of bronze, the hooks of the posts and their
bands were of silver, and the overlaying of their tops was of silver. All
the posts of the courtyard were banded with silver. 18 The hanging for
the gate of the court was of embroidered work, in blue, purple, and
scarlet yarn and fine twisted linen; about 30 feet in length,[g] and in
height about 7½ feet,[h] corresponding to the hangings of the court. 19
Their pillars were four, with their four sockets of bronze; their hooks
were of silver, and the overlay of their tops and their bands were of
silver. 20 And all the pegs for the tabernacle and for the court round
about were of bronze.

21 These are the records[i] of the tabernacle, the tabernacle of the
testimony, as they were recorded at the command of Moses, the
work of the Levites under the direction of Ithamar son of Aaron the
priest.[j] 22 Bezalel son of Uri, son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah, made
all that Yahweh commanded Moses. 23 And with him was Oholiab son
of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan, a craftsman and designer, and an
embroiderer in blue, purple, and scarlet yarn and fine linen.

24 All the gold that was used for the work, in all the work of the
sanctuary, the gold of the offering, came to about 2,200 pounds, by the
sanctuary standard.[k] 25 The silver from those of the congregation who
were counted came to about 7,500 pounds, by the sanctuary standard:[l]

[26] a fifth of an ounce a head,[m] that is, half the sanctuary standard, for
everyone who passed over to those who were counted, from twenty
years old and upward, for 603,550 men. [27] The 7,500 pounds[n] of silver
were used for casting the bases of the sanctuary and the bases of the
veil: a hundred bases from it, about 75 pounds for each base. [28] From
the remaining silver, about 44 pounds,[o] he made hooks for the posts,
overlaid their tops, and made bands for them. [29] The bronze of the
offering came to about 5,300 pounds.[p] [30] With it he made the sockets
at the entrance of the tent of meeting, and the bronze altar with its
bronze grating, and all the utensils for the altar, [31] and the sockets of
the court round about, and the sockets at the court gate, with all the
pegs of the tabernacle, and all the pegs of the court round about.

Notes

- a (38:1) Hebrew "five cubits long and five cubits wide … three cubits high," about 2.3 meters square and 1.4 meters high.
- b (38:8) Ancient mirrors were made of polished bronze.
- c (38:8) Hebrew tsava', used of organized service, including Levitical service at the sanctuary (Numbers 4:23; 8:24). Compare 1 Samuel 2:22. The nature of these women's service is not explained. The Septuagint reads "of the women who fasted."
- d (38:9) Hebrew "a hundred cubits," about 45 meters. So also in verse 11.
- e (38:12) Hebrew "fifty cubits," about 23 meters. So also in verse 13.
- f (38:14) Hebrew "fifteen cubits," about 6.8 meters. So also in verse 15.
- g (38:18) Hebrew "twenty cubits," about 9 meters.
- h (38:18) Hebrew "five cubits," about 2.3 meters.
- i (38:21) Or "the inventory."
- j (38:21) Verses 21–31 are an accounting of the materials. In the Septuagint, this material appears in a different place and form (see the note at 35:1).
- k (38:24) Hebrew "twenty-nine talents and seven hundred thirty shekels," about 1,000 kilograms. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms) and a shekel about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); a talent was 3,000 shekels. Standards varied, so these figures are approximate. On the "sanctuary standard" (Hebrew "shekel of the sanctuary"), see the note at 30:13. Some Septuagint manuscripts read 720 shekels.
- l (38:25) Hebrew "a hundred talents and one thousand seven hundred seventy-five shekels," about 3,400 kilograms.
- m (38:26) Hebrew "a beka a head, half a shekel," about 5.7 grams. The 603,550 contributors match the census in Numbers 1:46.
- n (38:27) Hebrew "the hundred talents," about 3,400 kilograms, that is, one talent (about 75 pounds or 34 kilograms) for each base.

- o (38:28) Hebrew “one thousand seven hundred seventy-five shekels,” about 20 kilograms.
- p (38:29) Hebrew “seventy talents and two thousand four hundred shekels,” about 2,400 kilograms.

Chapter 39

1 From the blue, purple, and scarlet yarn they made finely woven garments for ministering in the Holy Place. They made the holy garments for Aaron, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
2 He made the ephod of gold, blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen. 3 And they beat the gold into thin sheets and cut it into threads, to work it into the blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and the fine linen, with skillful design. 4 They made shoulder pieces for it, joined to it at its two edges, so that it was joined together. 5 And the skillfully woven band that was upon it was of the same piece and workmanship —of gold, blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen—as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
6 They prepared the onyx stones, set in settings of gold filigree, engraved as a seal is engraved, with the names of the sons of Israel. 7 And he set them on the shoulder straps of the ephod as memorial stones for the sons of Israel, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
8 He made the breastpiece, the work of a skilled designer, in the same style as the ephod, of gold, blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and fine twisted linen. 9 It was square. They made the breastpiece folded double, about 9 inches long and about 9 inches wide when folded.[a]
10 They set in it four rows of stones. A row of carnelian, topaz, and emerald was the first row;[b] 11 the second row a turquoise, a lapis lazuli, and a diamond; 12 the third row a jacinth, an agate, and an amethyst; 13 and the fourth row a beryl, an onyx, and a jasper. They were enclosed in settings of gold filigree. 14 And the stones were twelve, according to the names of the sons of Israel; each was engraved like a signet with its own name, for the twelve tribes. 15 And they made chains on the breastplate like cords, of braided work of pure gold. 16 They made two settings of gold filigree and two gold rings, and put the two rings on the two ends of the breastpiece. 17 And they put the two braided chains of gold in the two rings on the ends of the breastplate. 18 The

other two ends of the two cords they attached to the two settings, and so attached them to the shoulder pieces of the ephod at the front.
19 And they made two rings of gold and put them on the two ends of the breastplate, on its edge, which was on the inside toward the ephod. 20 They made two rings of gold and attached them to the two shoulder straps of the ephod, at the lower part, in front, close to its seam, above the skillfully woven band of the ephod. 21 And they tied the breastplate by its rings to the rings of the ephod with a blue cord, so that it might lie above the skillfully woven band of the ephod, and not come loose from the ephod, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
22 He made the robe of the ephod, woven work, all of blue. 23 In the middle of the robe was the opening, like the opening of a coat of mail,[c] with a binding all around the opening, so that it would not tear.
24 On the hem of the robe they made pomegranates of blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, and twisted linen. 25 They made bells of pure gold and set the bells between the pomegranates all around the hem of the robe, among the pomegranates: 26 a bell and a pomegranate, a bell and a pomegranate, around the hem of the robe for ministering, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
27 They made the tunics of fine linen, woven work, for Aaron and his sons, 28 and the turban of fine linen, the ornamental headbands of fine linen, the linen undergarments of fine twisted linen, 29 and the sash of fine twisted linen and blue, purple, and scarlet yarn, the work of an embroiderer, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
30 They made the plate of the holy crown of pure gold and wrote on it an inscription, like the engraving of a seal, “Holy to Yahweh.” 31 And they fastened to it a blue cord, to attach it above to the turban, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
32 So all the work of the tabernacle of the tent of meeting was finished. The Israelites did according to all that Yahweh had commanded Moses; so they did.
33 Then they brought the tabernacle to Moses, the tent and all its furnishings, its clasps, its frames, its crossbars, its posts, and its bases; 34 the covering of rams’ skins dyed red, the covering of fine leather, and the veil of the screen; 35 the ark of the testimony with its poles and

the atonement cover; [36] the table with all its utensils, and the bread of the Presence; [37] the pure lampstand with its lamps, the lamps set in order, and all its utensils, and the oil for the light; [38] the golden altar, the anointing oil, the fragrant incense, and the screen for the entrance of the tent; [39] the bronze altar with its grating of bronze, its poles, and all its utensils; the basin and its stand; [40] the hangings of the court, with its pillars and its sockets, and the hanging for the court gate, its cords and its pegs; and all the instruments for the service of the tabernacle, for the tent of meeting; [41] the finely woven garments for ministering in the Holy Place, the holy garments for Aaron the priest, and the garments of his sons for their service as priests. [42] According to all that Yahweh had commanded Moses, so the Israelites had done all the work. [43] Moses looked over all the work, and behold, they had done it; as Yahweh had commanded, so they had done. And Moses blessed them.[d]

Notes

- a (39:9) Hebrew "a span long and a span wide," about 23 centimeters square. See the note at 28:16.
- b (39:10) On the identification of these stones, see the notes at 28:17–18.
- c (39:23) See the note at 28:32.
- d (39:43) The completion and blessing echo the end of the creation account: compare Genesis 1:31–2:3.

Chapter 40

[1] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [2] "On the first day of the first month (in March–April)[a] you are to set up the tabernacle of the tent of meeting. [3] You are to put the ark of the testimony in it, and screen the ark with the veil. [4] You are to bring in the table and set out its arrangement. You are to bring in the lampstand and set up its lamps. [5] And you shall set the golden altar of incense before the ark of the testimony, and put up the hanging at the door of the tabernacle. [6] You are to put the altar of burnt offering before the entrance of the tabernacle of the tent of meeting, [7] and put the basin between the tent of meeting and the altar, and put water in it. [8] And you shall set up the court all around, and hang up the hanging at the court gate.

9 “And you shall take the anointing oil and anoint the tabernacle and
everything in it; and you shall hallow it and all its furniture, and it
shall be holy. 10 And you shall anoint the altar of burnt offering and all
its utensils, and sanctify the altar, and the altar shall be most holy. 11
You are to anoint the basin and its stand, and consecrate it. 12 Then you
are to bring Aaron and his sons to the entrance of the tent of meeting
and wash them with water, 13 and put the holy garments on Aaron;
and you shall anoint him and sanctify him, that he may minister to
me as priest. 14 You are to bring his sons and put tunics on them, 15
and anoint them as you anointed their father, so that they may serve
me as priests. Their anointing will make them a priesthood forever
throughout their generations.” 16 Moses did this; according to all that
Yahweh commanded him, so he did.
17 In the first month (March–April) of the second year, on the first
day of the month, the tabernacle was set up.[b] 18 Moses set up the
tabernacle. He laid its bases, set up its frames, put in its crossbars, and
raised its posts. 19 He spread the tent over the tabernacle and put the
covering of the tent over it, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
20 He took the testimony and put it into the ark. He set the poles on the
ark and put the atonement cover above on the ark. 21 And he brought
the ark into the tabernacle, and set up the veil of the covering, and
screened the ark of the testimony, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
22 He put the table in the tent of meeting, on the north side of the
tabernacle, outside the veil, 23 and arranged the bread on it before
Yahweh, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
24 He put the lampstand in the tent of meeting, opposite the table, on
the south side of the tabernacle, 25 and set up the lamps before Yahweh,
just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
26 He put the golden altar in the tent of meeting before the veil, 27 and
burned sweet incense on it, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
28 He set up the screen at the entrance of the tabernacle. 29 And he set
the altar of burnt offering by the door of the tabernacle of the tent of
meeting, and offered upon it the burnt offering and the grain offering,
as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

30 He put the basin between the tent of meeting and the altar, and
put water in it for washing. 31 Moses, Aaron, and his sons washed
their hands and their feet from it. 32 Whenever they entered the tent
of meeting and drew near the altar, they washed, as Yahweh had
commanded Moses. 33 He set up the courtyard around the tabernacle
and the altar, and hung up the screen of the gate of the courtyard. So
Moses finished the work.
34 Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of Yahweh
filled the tabernacle. 35 Moses was not able to enter the tent of meeting,
because the cloud settled[c] on it, and the glory of Yahweh filled the
tabernacle.
36 Whenever the cloud was taken up from over the tabernacle, the
Israelites would set out on all their journeys. 37 But if the cloud was
not taken up, they would not set out until the day that it was taken
up. 38 For the cloud of Yahweh was over the tabernacle by day, and fire
was in it[d] by night, in the sight of all the house of Israel, throughout
all their journeys.

Notes

- a (40:2) Hebrew "On the first day of the first month," that is, Abib or Nisan, the first month of the spring-start religious calendar. See the note at 12:2.
- b (40:17) Hebrew "In the first month in the second year, on the first of the month," that is, the first day of Abib or Nisan (see the note at 12:2), almost a year after the exodus (12:6; 19:1). The Septuagint adds "after they went out of Egypt."
- c (40:35) Hebrew shakan, "to dwell," the verb from which mishkan, "tabernacle," comes (see the note at 25:9). Later Jewish tradition spoke of God's dwelling presence as the Shekhinah.
- d (40:38) Or "in the cloud."

Leviticus

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Yahweh[a] called[b] to Moses[c] and spoke to him from the tent of
meeting,[d] saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and say to them: When any
man among you presents an offering[e] to Yahweh, you shall present
your offering from the livestock, from the herd or from the flock.
3 "If his offering is a burnt offering[f] from the herd, he is to offer a male
without defect. He is to offer it at the entrance of the tent of meeting,
so that he may be accepted[g] before Yahweh. 4 He shall lay[h] his hand
upon the head of the burnt offering, and it shall be accepted on his
behalf to make atonement[i] for him. 5 He is to slaughter the bull before
Yahweh, and Aaron's sons the priests are to present the blood and
splash[j] the blood all around against the altar that is at the entrance of
the tent of meeting. 6 He is to skin the burnt offering and cut it into
its pieces. 7 And the sons of Aaron the priest shall put fire upon the
altar, and arrange wood on the fire. 8 Then Aaron's sons the priests
shall lay the pieces, the head, and the suet[k] in order upon the wood
that is on the fire upon the altar. 9 Its entrails and its legs he is to wash
with water. Then the priest is to burn[l] all of it on the altar as a burnt
offering, an offering by fire,[m] a pleasing aroma[n] to Yahweh.
10 "If his offering for a burnt offering is of the flock, of the sheep or of
the goats, he shall bring a male without defect. 11 He is to slaughter
it on the north side of the altar before Yahweh, and Aaron's sons the
priests are to splash its blood all around against the altar. 12 He is to cut
it into its pieces, with its head and its suet, and the priest is to arrange
them on the wood that is on the fire on the altar. 13 The entrails and
the legs he is to wash with water. Then the priest is to offer all of it
and burn it on the altar. It is a burnt offering, an offering by fire, a
pleasing aroma to Yahweh.

14 “If his offering to Yahweh is a burnt offering of birds, he is to bring
his offering from the turtledoves or from the young pigeons. 15 The
priest is to bring it to the altar, wring off its head, and burn it on the
altar. Its blood is to be drained out against the side of the altar. 16 He
is to remove its crop with its contents[o] and throw it beside the altar
on the east side, in the place for the ashes.[p] 17 He is to tear it open by
its wings without dividing it completely. Then the priest is to burn it
on the altar, on the wood that is on the fire. It is a burnt offering, an
offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh.

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew YHWH, the personal name of God, written with four consonants and traditionally read aloud as Adonai, “Lord.” This translation writes it as Yahweh throughout; on its meaning, see the note at Exodus 3:15.
- b (1:1) Hebrew wayyiqra, “and he called,” the first word of the book and its Hebrew title. In the Masoretic Text the final letter aleph of this word is written small, a scribal tradition with no agreed explanation. The English title Leviticus comes from the Septuagint and Vulgate, “the book of the Levites,” though the book mostly concerns the priests.
- c (1:1) Moses is probably an Egyptian name meaning “son” or “born,” explained in Hebrew as “drawn out” (Exodus 2:10).
- d (1:1) Hebrew ’ohel mo‘ed, the tent where Yahweh met with Moses and Israel (Exodus 25:22; 29:42–43; 40:34–35).
- e (1:2) Hebrew qorban, from qarav, “to come near” or “bring near”: something brought near to God.
- f (1:3) Hebrew ‘olah, literally “that which goes up,” because the whole animal went up in smoke. The Septuagint calls it holokautoma, “wholly burned,” the source of the English word “holocaust.”
- g (1:3) Or “so that it may be accepted for him”; the Hebrew lirtsono can refer to either the offering or the worshiper.
- h (1:4) Hebrew samakh, “lean” or “press.” Whether this hand-leaning marked ownership, identification with the animal, or the transfer of sin (as in 16:21) is debated.
- i (1:4) Hebrew kipper. Its basic sense is debated: “to cover,” “to wipe away” or “purge,” or “to ransom” (compare the related noun kopher, “ransom,” in Exodus 30:12). The burnt offering atones in a general sense, before the specific sin and guilt offerings are introduced in chapters 4–5.
- j (1:5) Hebrew zaraq, to throw or dash liquid from a bowl, not to sprinkle with the finger (compare 4:6).

- k (1:8) Hebrew peder, a word found only in Leviticus 1:8, 12, and 8:20. It is probably the fat around the organs, though some take it to be the head's fat or the cut-up pieces.
- l (1:9) Hebrew hiqtir, literally "turn into smoke." It is a different verb from saraph, used of burning things outside the camp (4:12).
- m (1:9) Hebrew 'ishsheh, traditionally connected with 'esh, "fire." Some scholars relate it to a word for "gift" and translate "food gift" or "food offering" (compare "the food of God" in 21:6).
- n (1:9) Literally "an aroma of soothing" (reach nichoach), a phrase that speaks of God's acceptance of the offering, first used in Genesis 8:21.
- o (1:16) Or "with its feathers"; the Hebrew notsah is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "with its feathers."
- p (1:16) Literally "the place of the fat ashes," fat-soaked ashes removed from the altar (see 6:10–11).

Chapter 2

1 "When anyone[a] presents a grain offering[b] to Yahweh as his offering,
it shall be of fine flour;[c] and he shall pour oil on it, and put frankincense[d] on it. 2 And he shall bring it to Aaron's sons the priests; and the
priest shall take from it a handful of its fine flour and of its oil, with
all its frankincense, and shall burn it upon the altar as its memorial
portion,[e] a fire offering of pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 3 What is left
of the grain offering belongs to Aaron and his sons. It is a most holy
part of Yahweh's offerings by fire.
4 "When you bring as an offering a grain offering baked in an oven,[f] it
is to be unleavened loaves of fine flour mixed with oil, or unleavened
wafers spread with oil. 5 If your offering is a grain offering made on
a griddle, it is to be of fine flour mixed with oil, unleavened. 6 You are
to break it in pieces and pour oil on it. It is a grain offering. 7 If your
offering is a grain offering cooked in a pan,[g] it is to be made of fine
flour with oil. 8 You are to bring to Yahweh the grain offering that is
made of these things. It is to be presented to the priest, and he is to
bring it to the altar. 9 The priest is to lift out from the grain offering
its memorial portion and burn it on the altar, an offering by fire, a
pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 10 What is left of the grain offering belongs
to Aaron and his sons. It is a most holy part of Yahweh's offerings
by fire.

11 “No grain offering that you bring to Yahweh shall be made with
leaven; for you shall not burn any leaven or any honey[h] as a fire
offering to Yahweh. 12 As an offering of firstfruits[i] you may bring them
to Yahweh, but they are not to go up on the altar as a pleasing aroma.
13 You are to season every grain offering of yours with salt. You must
not leave out from your grain offering the salt of the covenant[j] of
your God. With all your offerings you are to offer salt.
14 “If you bring a grain offering of firstfruits to Yahweh, you are to
bring as the grain offering of your firstfruits fresh ears roasted in the
fire, crushed grain from new ears.[k] 15 You are to put oil on it and lay
frankincense on it. It is a grain offering. 16 And the priest shall burn
the memorial portion of it, part of its crushed grain and part of its oil,
along with all its frankincense, as a fire offering to Yahweh.

Notes

- a (2:1) Hebrew nephesh, “a soul,” “a person,” here meaning anyone at all.
- b (2:1) Hebrew minchah, which elsewhere means a “gift” or “tribute” of any kind (Genesis 4:3–5; 32:13). In the priestly laws it is the offering of grain, and that is how it is translated here.
- c (2:1) Hebrew solet, probably semolina, the finest grade of wheat flour.
- d (2:1) An aromatic resin from trees of southern Arabia and East Africa (genus Boswellia).
- e (2:2) Hebrew ’azkarah, probably “reminder,” the part that “calls to remembrance” the worshiper before God; others render “token portion.”
- f (2:4) Hebrew tannur, a clay oven heated from inside, with dough baked on its walls.
- g (2:7) Hebrew marchesheth, probably a deep pan, as opposed to the flat griddle (machavath) of verse 5.
- h (2:11) Hebrew devash, which may include fruit syrup (especially from dates) as well as bees’ honey. Both leaven and honey ferment.
- i (2:12) Hebrew re’shit, the first and best part of the harvest (compare 23:10, 17).
- j (2:13) A covenant meant to last, since salt preserves (Numbers 18:19; 2 Chronicles 13:5). Eating salt together was a sign of a binding agreement in the ancient Near East.
- k (2:14) Hebrew karmel, probably fresh, full ears of new grain. The exact process described is uncertain.

Chapter 3

1 “If someone’s offering is a sacrifice of peace offerings,[a] and he offers
it from the herd, whether male or female, he is to offer it without
defect before Yahweh. 2 He is to lay his hand on the head of his
offering and slaughter it at the entrance of the tent of meeting, and
Aaron’s sons the priests are to splash the blood all around against the
altar. 3 From the sacrifice of peace offerings he is to present an offering
by fire to Yahweh: the fat that covers the entrails and all the fat that
is on the entrails, 4 and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them by
the loins, and the lobe[b] over the liver, which he shall take away with
the kidneys. 5 Aaron’s sons are to burn it on the altar on top of the
burnt offering that is on the wood on the fire. It is an offering by fire,
a pleasing aroma to Yahweh.
6 “If his offering for a sacrifice of peace offerings to Yahweh is from
the flock, male or female, he is to offer it without defect. 7 If he offers
a lamb for his offering, he is to present it before Yahweh. 8 He is to lay
his hand on the head of his offering and slaughter it in front of the
tent of meeting, and Aaron’s sons are to splash its blood all around
against the altar. 9 From the sacrifice of peace offerings he is to present
as an offering by fire to Yahweh its fat: the whole fat tail,[c] which he is
to remove close to the backbone, the fat that covers the entrails and
all the fat that is on the entrails, 10 and the two kidneys and the fat that
is on them by the loins, and the lobe over the liver, which he shall
take away with the kidneys. 11 The priest is to burn it on the altar as
food,[d] an offering by fire to Yahweh.
12 “If his offering is a goat, he is to present it before Yahweh.[e] 13 He
is to lay his hand on its head and slaughter it in front of the tent
of meeting, and the sons of Aaron are to splash its blood all around
against the altar. 14 From it he is to present his offering as an offering
by fire to Yahweh: the fat that covers the entrails and all the fat that
is on the entrails, 15 and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them
by the loins, and the lobe over the liver, which he shall take away
with the kidneys. 16 The priest is to burn them on the altar as food, an
offering by fire for a pleasing aroma. All fat belongs to Yahweh. 17 It is

a statute forever throughout your generations, in all your dwellings: you must not eat any fat or any blood."

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew zevach shelamim. The word shelamim is related to shalom, "peace, wholeness, well-being," and the offering is also translated "fellowship offering" or "offering of well-being." Its meat was shared by God (the fat), the priest, and the worshiper (7:11–36).
- b (3:4) Hebrew yothereth, "appendage" or "lobe," probably the caudate lobe of the liver.
- c (3:9) The broad, fatty tail of the Middle Eastern fat-tailed sheep, which can weigh many pounds.
- d (3:11) Literally "the food of the offering by fire." Hebrew lechem, "bread" or "food." The phrase is an old expression for the offering; the Bible itself denies that God needs food (Psalm 50:12–13). The Septuagint reads "a sweet-smelling offering."
- e (3:12) A Greek papyrus of Leviticus from Qumran (pap4QLXXLev-b) writes God's name in this chapter and the next as Iao, a Greek form of the name Yahweh, rather than kyrios, "Lord." It is one of the earliest pieces of evidence that the name was pronounced.

Chapter 4

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites, saying: If anyone sins unintentionally[a] against any of the commandments of Yahweh concerning things which ought not to be done, and does any one of them:

3 "If it is the anointed priest[b] who sins, bringing guilt on the people, he is to offer to Yahweh for the sin that he has committed a young bull without defect as a sin offering.[c] 4 He is to bring the bull to the entrance of the tent of meeting before Yahweh, lay his hand on the bull's head, and slaughter the bull before Yahweh. 5 Then the anointed priest is to take some of the bull's blood and bring it into the tent of meeting. 6 And the priest shall dip his finger in the blood, and sprinkle some of the blood seven times before Yahweh, facing the veil of the sanctuary. 7 The priest is to put some of the blood on the horns of the altar of fragrant incense before Yahweh, which is in the tent of meeting, and all the rest of the bull's blood he is to pour out at the base of the altar of burnt offering, which is at the entrance of the tent of meeting. 8 All the fat of the bull of the sin offering he is to remove from it: the fat that covers the entrails and all the fat that is on the

entrails, 9 and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them by the loins,
and the lobe over the liver, which he shall take away with the kidneys,
10 as it is taken from the ox of the sacrifice of peace offerings; and the
priest shall burn them upon the altar of burnt offering. 11 But the hide
of the bull and all its flesh, with its head, its legs, its entrails, and its
dung, 12 the entire bull he shall carry out of the camp to a clean place,
to the dumping place for ashes, and burn it with fire on wood; at the
dumping place for ashes it shall be burned.
13 "If the whole congregation of Israel errs through ignorance, and
the matter is hidden from the eyes of the assembly, and they do
something against any of Yahweh's commandments about things not
to be done, and are guilty,[d] 14 when the sin which they have committed
becomes known, then the assembly shall offer a young bull for a sin
offering, and bring it before the tent of meeting. 15 The elders of the
congregation are to lay their hands on the head of the bull before
Yahweh, and the bull is to be slaughtered before Yahweh. 16 Then the
anointed priest is to bring some of the bull's blood into the tent of
meeting. 17 and the priest shall dip his finger in the blood and sprinkle
it seven times before Yahweh, facing the veil. 18 And he shall put some
of the blood on the horns of the altar that is before Yahweh, in the
tent of meeting; and everything that remains of the blood he shall
pour at the base of the altar of burnt offering, which is at the entrance
of the tent of meeting. 19 All its fat he is to remove from it and burn
on the altar. 20 He is to do with the bull just as he did with the bull
of the sin offering; so he is to do with this one. The priest is to make
atonement for them, and they will be forgiven. 21 He is to carry the
bull outside the camp and burn it as he burned the first bull. It is the
sin offering for the assembly.
22 "When a ruler[e] sins, and unintentionally does any one of all the
things which Yahweh his God has commanded not to be done, and
is guilty, 23 or if his sin, in which he has sinned, is made known to
him, he shall bring as his offering a male goat, a male without defect.
24 He is to lay his hand on the head of the goat and slaughter it in
the place where the burnt offering is slaughtered before Yahweh. It
is a sin offering. 25 The priest is to take some of the blood of the sin

offering with his finger and put it on the horns of the altar of burnt offering, and pour out the rest of its blood at the base of the altar of burnt offering. 26 All its fat he is to burn on the altar, like the fat of the sacrifice of peace offerings. So the priest is to make atonement for him for his sin, and he will be forgiven.

27 "If any one of the people of the land[f] sins unintentionally by doing any one of the things that Yahweh has commanded not to be done, and becomes guilty, 28 or if his sin, in which he has sinned, is made known to him, then he shall bring as his offering a female goat, a female without defect, for the sin he has committed. 29 He is to lay his hand on the head of the sin offering and slaughter the sin offering in the place of the burnt offering. 30 And the priest shall take some of its blood with his finger and put it on the horns of the altar of burnt offering, and he shall pour out all the rest of its blood at the base of the altar. 31 All its fat he is to remove, just as the fat is removed from the sacrifice of peace offerings, and the priest is to burn it on the altar for a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. So the priest is to make atonement for him, and he will be forgiven.

32 "If he brings a lamb as his offering for a sin offering, he is to bring a female without defect. 33 He is to lay his hand on the head of the sin offering and slaughter it as a sin offering in the place where the burnt offering is slaughtered. 34 And the priest shall take some of the blood of the sin offering with his finger and put it on the horns of the altar of burnt offering, and shall pour out all the rest of its blood at the base of the altar. 35 He shall take away all its fat, as the fat of the lamb is taken from the sacrifice of the peace offerings; and the priest shall burn it on the altar, upon Yahweh's fire offerings. So the priest shall make atonement for him concerning the sin he has committed, and he shall be forgiven.

Notes

- a (4:2) Hebrew bishgagah, "in error" or "inadvertently," whether through ignorance of the law or by accident. Deliberate, defiant sin ("with a high hand," Numbers 15:30) is not covered by these offerings.
- b (4:3) The high priest (compare 8:12; 21:10).
- c (4:3) Hebrew chatta't, the same word as "sin." Many scholars, following Jacob Milgrom, translate it "purification offering," because its blood purges the sanctuary

and its objects of the defilement caused by sin and impurity, and because it is also required where no moral wrong was done (12:6–8; 15:15). The traditional "sin offering" is kept here, but the offering's main work is purification.

- d (4:13) Hebrew 'asham, which can mean "be guilty," "incur guilt," or "feel guilt," that is, realize one's guilt. The same question arises in verses 22 and 27 and in 5:2–5, 17.
- e (4:22) Hebrew nasi', a tribal chief (Numbers 1:16; 7:2).
- f (4:27) Hebrew 'am ha'arets, here the ordinary members of the community as distinct from priests and leaders.

Chapter 5

1 "If anyone sins, in that he hears a public charge to testify,[a] and is a
witness, whether he has seen or known of the matter, and does not
report it, then he shall bear his iniquity. 2 Or if anyone touches any
unclean thing, whether the carcass of an unclean wild animal, or the
carcass of unclean livestock, or the carcass of an unclean swarming
creature,[b] and it is hidden from him, and he has become unclean, then
he is guilty. 3 Or if he touches human uncleanness, any uncleanness of
any kind by which one becomes unclean, and it is hidden from him,
when he comes to know it, then he is guilty. 4 Or if anyone rashly
swears an oath with his lips to do evil or to do good, in any matter
that a person may speak rashly with an oath, and it is hidden from
him, when he comes to know it, then he is guilty in one of these. 5
When he becomes guilty in one of these, he is to confess the way in
which he has sinned. 6 He is to bring to Yahweh as his penalty[c] for the
sin that he has committed a female from the flock, a lamb or a goat,
as a sin offering. The priest is to make atonement for him for his sin.
7 "But if he cannot afford a lamb,[d] he is to bring to Yahweh as his
penalty for the sin he has committed two turtledoves or two young
pigeons, one for a sin offering and the other for a burnt offering. 8
He is to bring them to the priest, who is to offer first the one for the
sin offering. He is to wring its head at the front of its neck, but not
sever it completely. 9 And he shall sprinkle some of the blood of the
sin offering on the side of the altar, while the rest of the blood shall
be drained out at the base of the altar; it is a sin offering. 10 The second
he is to offer as a burnt offering according to the regulation. So the

priest is to make atonement for him for the sin he has committed, and he will be forgiven.

11 "But if he cannot afford two turtledoves or two young pigeons, then for his sin he shall bring as his offering about 2 quarts[e] of fine flour for a sin offering; he shall put no oil on it and shall lay no frankincense on it, for it is a sin offering. 12 He shall bring it to the priest, who shall take a handful of it as the memorial portion, and burn it on the altar, upon Yahweh's fire offerings; it is a sin offering. 13 So the priest shall make atonement for him concerning the sin that he has committed in any of these things, and he shall be forgiven; and the remainder shall belong to the priest, like the grain offering."

14 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 15 "If anyone commits a breach of faith[f] and sins unintentionally against any of Yahweh's holy things, he is to bring to Yahweh as his penalty a ram without defect from the flock, valued in silver[g] by the sanctuary standard,[h] as a guilt offering.[i] 16 And he shall make restitution for what he has sinned against the holy thing, and shall add a fifth to it and give it to the priest; and the priest shall make atonement for him with the ram of the guilt offering, and it shall be forgiven him.

17 "If anyone sins and does any one of all the things that Yahweh has commanded not to be done, though he does not know it, he is guilty and will bear his iniquity. 18 He shall bring to the priest a ram without defect out of the flock, according to your valuation, for a guilt offering; and the priest shall make atonement for him regarding the error he committed unintentionally and did not know, and he shall be forgiven. 19 It is a guilt offering; he is indeed guilty before Yahweh."[j]

Notes

- a (5:1) Literally "hears the voice of an oath ('alah)," a public curse or summons laid on anyone who knows something about a crime and keeps silent (compare Judges 17:2; Proverbs 29:24).
- b (5:2) Hebrew sherets, small creatures that swarm on land or in water (11:10, 20, 29).
- c (5:6) Hebrew 'asham, here the penalty or reparation owed, the same word used for the "guilt offering" in verses 14–19. The Septuagint reads "for his trespass."
- d (5:7) Literally "if his hand cannot reach the sufficiency of a lamb." This sliding scale for the poor appears again in 12:8 and 14:21–32.

- e (5:11) Hebrew “a tenth of an ephah,” about 2.2 liters. Ancient standards varied.
- f (5:15) Hebrew maʿal, the misuse of something holy that belongs to God, a breach of trust against him.
- g (5:15) Hebrew “in silver shekels.” No number is given; the Hebrew plural may imply a minimum of two shekels (about 0.8 ounce or 23 grams), as many interpreters hold, or it may simply mean “its value in silver.”
- h (5:15) Hebrew “by the shekel of the sanctuary,” a standard shekel of 20 gerahs (27:25; Exodus 30:13), about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams). Ancient standards varied.
- i (5:15) Hebrew ’asham, also translated “reparation offering,” since it goes with restitution for a wrong done against God’s holy things or against a neighbor (6:1–7).
- j (5:19) Or “he has indeed made himself guilty before Yahweh.” The Septuagint reads “for he has indeed trespassed before the Lord.”

Chapter 6

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying,[a] 2 “If anyone sins and commits a
breach of faith against Yahweh by deceiving his neighbor about a
deposit or a pledge, or by robbery, or if he has defrauded his neighbor,
3 or has found what was lost and lied about it, and sworn falsely—
in any of all the things that a man may do in which he sins— 4 then,
when he has sinned and is guilty, he is to return what he took by
robbery or what he gained by fraud, or the deposit that was entrusted
to him, or the lost thing that he found, 5 or anything about which he
has sworn falsely; he shall make full restitution for it, adding a fifth
more, and give it to its owner on the day he is found guilty.[b] 6 Then
he is to bring to Yahweh as his guilt offering a ram without defect
from the flock, at your valuation, as a guilt offering to the priest. 7
The priest is to make atonement for him before Yahweh, and he will
be forgiven for any one of all the things that he may do and become
guilty by it.”
8 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 9 “Command Aaron and his sons,
saying, This is the law[c] of the burnt offering. The burnt offering is to
stay on its hearth[d] on the altar all night until the morning, and the
fire of the altar is to be kept burning on it. 10 The priest is to put on
his linen garment, with linen undergarments on his body, and he is
to take up the fat ashes to which the fire has consumed the burnt
offering on the altar, and put them beside the altar. 11 Then he is to

take off his garments and put on other garments, and carry the fat ashes outside the camp to a clean place. 12 The fire on the altar shall be kept burning on it; it shall not go out. And the priest shall burn wood on it every morning, and lay the burnt offering in order on it, and shall burn on it the fat of the peace offerings. 13 Fire is to be kept burning on the altar continually; it must not go out.
14 "This is the law of the grain offering. The sons of Aaron are to offer it before Yahweh in front of the altar. 15 One of them is to take from it a handful of the fine flour of the grain offering and of its oil, with all the frankincense that is on the grain offering, and burn its memorial portion on the altar as a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 16 What is left of it Aaron and his sons are to eat. It is to be eaten unleavened in a holy place; in the court of the tent of meeting they are to eat it. 17 It must not be baked with leaven. I have given it as their portion from my offerings by fire. It is most holy, like the sin offering and the guilt offering. 18 Every male among the children of Aaron shall eat of it, as a statute forever throughout your generations, from Yahweh's offerings made by fire; whatever touches them shall be holy."[e]
19 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 20 "This is the offering that Aaron and his sons are to offer to Yahweh on the day when he is anointed:[f] about 2 quarts[g] of fine flour as a regular grain offering, half of it in the morning and half of it in the evening. 21 It is to be made with oil on a griddle. You are to bring it well mixed, and offer the grain offering in broken pieces[h] as a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 22 The priest from among Aaron's sons who is anointed in his place is to offer it. It is Yahweh's portion forever; it is to be burned entirely. 23 Every grain offering of a priest is to be burned entirely. It must not be eaten."
24 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 25 "Speak to Aaron and to his sons, saying, This is the law of the sin offering. In the place where the burnt offering is slaughtered, the sin offering is to be slaughtered before Yahweh. It is most holy. 26 The priest who offers it for sin shall eat it; it shall be eaten in a holy place, in the court of the tent of meeting. 27 Whatever touches its flesh will become holy. When any of its blood is splashed on a garment, you are to wash the part on which it was splashed in a holy place. 28 The clay pot in which it is boiled is to be

broken. If it is boiled in a bronze pot, that pot is to be scoured and rinsed in water. 29 Every male among the priests may eat it. It is most holy. 30 But no sin offering from which any blood is brought into the tent of meeting to make atonement in the Holy Place may be eaten. It is to be burned with fire.

Notes

- a (6:1) Verses 6:1–7 of the English versification appear as 5:20–26 in the Hebrew Bible, and 6:8–30 appear there as 6:1–23. Here the usual English chapter and verse numbering is kept.
- b (6:5) Or "on the day of his guilt offering."
- c (6:9) Hebrew torah, "instruction" or "regulation," here a ritual procedure. The same formula introduces each section in 6:8–7:38.
- d (6:9) Hebrew moqedah, "burning place," found only here.
- e (6:18) Or "Anyone who touches them must be holy," that is, only priests in a state of holiness may touch them. The meaning of this phrase, here and in verse 27 (compare Exodus 29:37), is debated: whether holiness passes to what touches the offering, or whether only those already holy may touch it.
- f (6:20) Or "from the day when he is anointed," an offering made each day from then on (compare "regular" in this verse). The Septuagint reads "on the day when you anoint him."
- g (6:20) Hebrew "a tenth of an ephah," about 2.2 liters. Ancient standards varied.
- h (6:21) Hebrew tuphine, a word found only here; its meaning is uncertain. It may mean "baked pieces" or "broken pieces."

Chapter 7

1 "This is the law of the guilt offering. It is most holy. 2 At the place where the burnt offering is slaughtered, the guilt offering shall be slaughtered, and its blood shall be dashed on the altar all around. 3 All its fat is to be offered: the fat tail, the fat that covers the entrails, 4 and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them by the loins, and the lobe over the liver, which he shall take away with the kidneys. 5 And the priest shall burn them upon the altar as an offering made by fire to Yahweh; it is a guilt offering. 6 Every male among the priests may eat it. It is to be eaten in a holy place. It is most holy. 7 The guilt offering is like the sin offering; there is one law for them. It belongs to the priest who makes atonement with it. 8 The priest who offers anyone's burnt offering is to have for himself the hide of the burnt offering that he has offered. 9 Every grain offering baked in the oven, and all that is

prepared in the frying pan or on the griddle, shall be the priest's who offers it. 10 Every grain offering, mixed with oil or dry, belongs to all the sons of Aaron, to one as much as to another.
11 "This is the law of the sacrifice of peace offerings that one may offer to Yahweh. 12 If he offers it for thanksgiving,[a] then along with the sacrifice of thanksgiving he is to offer unleavened loaves mixed with oil, unleavened wafers spread with oil, and loaves of fine flour well mixed with oil. 13 With loaves of leavened bread he is to present his offering, along with his sacrifice of peace offerings for thanksgiving. 14 From it he is to offer one of each kind of offering as a contribution[b] to Yahweh. It belongs to the priest who splashes the blood of the peace offerings. 15 As for the flesh of the sacrifice of his peace offerings for thanksgiving, it shall be eaten on the day of his offering; he shall not leave any of it until morning. 16 But if the sacrifice of his offering is a vow or a freewill offering, it shall be eaten the same day that he offers his sacrifice; and on the next day the remainder of it may be eaten; 17 What is left of the flesh of the sacrifice on the third day is to be burned with fire. 18 If any of the flesh of his sacrifice of peace offerings is eaten on the third day, it will not be accepted. It will not be credited to the one who offers it. It is a foul thing,[c] and the person who eats of it will bear his iniquity.
19 "Flesh that touches anything unclean must not be eaten; it is to be burned with fire. As for other flesh, everyone who is clean may eat flesh. 20 But the person who eats flesh from the sacrifice of peace offerings that belongs to Yahweh while his uncleanness is on him, that person will be cut off[d] from his people. 21 When anyone touches anything unclean, whether human uncleanness or an unclean animal or any unclean detestable thing,[e] and then eats some of the flesh of the sacrifice of peace offerings that belongs to Yahweh, that person will be cut off from his people."
22 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 23 "Speak to the Israelites, saying, You must not eat any fat of ox, sheep, or goat. 24 The fat of a carcass and the fat of what is torn by beasts may be used for any other purpose; but you shall in no way eat of it. 25 For whoever eats the fat of an animal from which an offering by fire may be offered to Yahweh, the

person who eats it will be cut off from his people. 26 You must not eat
any blood, whether of bird or of animal, in any of your dwellings. 27
Whoever eats any blood, that person will be cut off from his people."
28 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 29 "Speak to the Israelites, saying,
Whoever offers his sacrifice of peace offerings to Yahweh is to bring
his offering to Yahweh from his sacrifice of peace offerings. 30 His
own hands are to bring Yahweh's offerings by fire. He is to bring
the fat with the breast, so that the breast may be waved as a wave
offering[f] before Yahweh. 31 The priest is to burn the fat on the altar,
but the breast belongs to Aaron and his sons. 32 The right thigh you
are to give to the priest as a contribution from your sacrifices of peace
offerings. 33 The one among the sons of Aaron who offers the blood
of the peace offerings and the fat shall have the right thigh for his
portion. 34 For I have taken from the Israelites, out of their sacrifices
of peace offerings, the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the
contribution, and have given them to Aaron the priest and to his sons
as a due forever from the Israelites. 35 This is the portion of Aaron and
the portion of his sons from Yahweh's offerings by fire, from the day
when he[g] presented them to serve as priests to Yahweh. 36 Yahweh
commanded this to be given them by the Israelites on the day that he
anointed them. It is a due forever throughout their generations."
37 This is the law concerning the burnt offering, the grain offering,
the sin offering, the guilt offering, the consecration offering,[h] and
the peace offering sacrifice, 38 which Yahweh commanded Moses on
Mount Sinai on the day that he commanded the Israelites to bring
their offerings to Yahweh, in the wilderness of Sinai.

Notes

- a (7:12) Hebrew todah, "thanksgiving" or "praise," a peace offering given in gratitude for deliverance (compare Psalm 107:22; 116:17).
- b (7:14) Hebrew terumah, a contribution set apart, literally "something lifted off."
- c (7:18) Hebrew piggul, a technical term for sacrificial meat that has become unfit because it was kept too long (19:7; Ezekiel 4:14; Isaiah 65:4).
- d (7:20) Hebrew karath. Whether this penalty meant execution by the community, early death at God's hand, or the cutting off of one's descendants is debated. Many rabbinic interpreters took it as a punishment from God rather than a human court.

- e (7:21) Hebrew sheqets. Many Hebrew manuscripts, the Samaritan Pentateuch, and the Syriac read sherets, “swarming creature,” as in 5:2.
- f (7:30) Hebrew tenufah, an offering presented by moving it toward the altar and back, or lifting it up. Jacob Milgrom and others argue the rite was a lifting, a “presentation offering.”
- g (7:35) Probably Moses (compare 8:1–30); the Hebrew may also be read “from the day when they were presented.”
- h (7:37) Hebrew millu’im, literally “filling,” from the phrase “fill the hand,” meaning to install someone in priestly office (8:33; Exodus 29:9).

Chapter 8

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 “Take Aaron and his sons with
him, and the garments, the anointing oil, the bull of the sin offering,
the two rams, and the basket of unleavened bread, 3 and assemble the
whole congregation at the entrance of the tent of meeting.” 4 Moses
did as Yahweh commanded him, and the congregation was assembled
at the entrance of the tent of meeting. 5 Moses said to the congrega-
tion, “This is the thing that Yahweh has commanded to be done.”
6 Then Moses brought Aaron and his sons forward and washed them
with water. 7 He put the tunic on him, tied the sash around him,
clothed him with the robe, and put the ephod[a] on him. He tied the
woven band of the ephod around him and fastened the ephod to him
with it. 8 He placed the breastplate upon him, and in the breastplate
he put the Urim and the Thummim.[b] 9 He set the turban on his head,
and on the turban, at its front, he set the gold plate, the holy crown,[c]
as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
10 Then Moses took the anointing oil and anointed the tabernacle and
everything in it, and consecrated them. 11 He sprinkled some of it on
the altar seven times, and anointed the altar and all its utensils, and
the basin and its stand, to consecrate them. 12 He poured some of the
anointing oil on Aaron’s head and anointed him to consecrate him. 13
Then Moses brought Aaron’s sons forward, clothed them with tunics,
tied sashes around them, and bound caps on them, as Yahweh had
commanded Moses.
14 Then he brought the bull of the sin offering, and Aaron and his
sons laid their hands on the head of the bull of the sin offering. 15
And he killed it; and Moses took the blood, and put some with his

finger on the horns of the altar all around, and purified[d] the altar; then he poured out the blood at the base of the altar and sanctified it, to make atonement for it. 16 He took all the fat that was on the entrails, the lobe of the liver, and the two kidneys with their fat, and Moses burned them on the altar. 17 But the bull, its hide, its flesh, and its dung he burned with fire outside the camp, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
18 Then he presented the ram of the burnt offering, and Aaron and his sons laid their hands on the ram's head. 19 He slaughtered it, and Moses splashed the blood all around against the altar. 20 He cut the ram into its pieces, and Moses burned the head, the pieces, and the suet. 21 He washed the entrails and the legs with water, and Moses burned the whole ram on the altar. It was a burnt offering for a pleasing aroma, an offering by fire to Yahweh, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
22 Then he presented the other ram, the ram of ordination, and Aaron and his sons laid their hands on the ram's head. 23 He slaughtered it, and Moses took some of its blood and put it on the lobe of Aaron's right ear, on the thumb of his right hand, and on the big toe of his right foot. 24 Then he brought Aaron's sons, and Moses put some of the blood on the tips of their right ears, and on the thumbs of their right hands, and on the big toes of their right feet; and Moses sprinkled the blood all around upon the altar. 25 He took the fat, the fat tail, all the fat that was on the entrails, the lobe of the liver, the two kidneys with their fat, and the right thigh; 26 and from the basket of unleavened bread that was before Yahweh he took one unleavened loaf, one loaf of bread made with oil, and one wafer, and placed them on the fat and on the right thigh. 27 He put all these in the hands of Aaron and in the hands of his sons, and waved them as a wave offering before Yahweh. 28 Then Moses took them from their hands and burned them on the altar on top of the burnt offering. They were an ordination offering for a pleasing aroma, an offering by fire to Yahweh. 29 Moses took the breast and waved it as a wave offering before Yahweh. It was Moses' portion of the ram of ordination, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.
30 Then Moses took some of the anointing oil and some of the blood that was on the altar and sprinkled it on Aaron and his garments, and

on his sons and on his sons' garments with him. So he consecrated Aaron and his garments, and his sons and his sons' garments with him.

31 Moses said to Aaron and his sons, "Boil the flesh at the entrance of the tent of meeting, and eat it there with the bread that is in the basket of ordination offerings, as I commanded, saying,[e] 'Aaron and his sons are to eat it.' 32 What is left of the flesh and of the bread you are to burn with fire. 33 And you shall not go out from the door of the tent of meeting for seven days, until the days of your consecration are fulfilled; for seven days he shall consecrate you.[f] 34 As has been done today, Yahweh has commanded to be done, to make atonement for you. 35 At the entrance of the tent of meeting you are to remain day and night for seven days, keeping Yahweh's charge, so that you do not die, for so I have been commanded." 36 Aaron and his sons did all the things that Yahweh commanded through Moses.[g]

Notes

- a (8:7) A priestly garment worn over the robe, probably like an apron or vest, held by shoulder pieces and a woven band (Exodus 28:6–14). Its exact form is uncertain.
- b (8:8) Objects kept in the breastpiece and used to learn God's decision (Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21). The words may mean "lights and perfections"; how the objects worked is unknown.
- c (8:9) Hebrew tsits, "flower" or "shining plate," engraved "Holy to Yahweh" (Exodus 28:36). Nezer, "crown," also means "consecration."
- d (8:15) Hebrew chitte', "to de-sin" or "purge," from the same root as chatta't, "sin offering."
- e (8:31) The Hebrew vowels read "as I commanded"; the Septuagint, Syriac, and Targum read "as I was commanded," as in verse 35.
- f (8:33) Literally "for seven days he will fill your hand." See the note at 7:37.
- g (8:36) Literally "by the hand of Moses."

Chapter 9

1 On the eighth day Moses called Aaron and his sons and the elders of Israel. 2 He said to Aaron, "Take for yourself a calf from the herd for a sin offering and a ram for a burnt offering, both without defect, and offer them before Yahweh. 3 And to the Israelites you shall say, 'Take a kid of the goats for a sin offering, and a calf and a lamb, both a year old, without defect, for a burnt offering, 4 and an ox and a ram

for peace offerings, to sacrifice before Yahweh, with a grain offering mixed with oil; for today Yahweh is going to appear to you.'" 5 So they brought what Moses commanded before the tent of meeting, and all the congregation drew near and stood before Yahweh. 6 Moses said, "This is the thing that Yahweh commanded you to do, so that the glory of Yahweh may appear to you." 7 Then Moses said to Aaron, "Come near to the altar and offer your sin offering and your burnt offering, and make atonement for yourself and for the people.[a] Then offer the people's offering and make atonement for them, as Yahweh has commanded."
8 So Aaron came near to the altar and slaughtered the calf of the sin offering, which was for himself. 9 Aaron's sons presented the blood to him, and he dipped his finger in the blood and put it on the horns of the altar, and poured out the blood at the base of the altar. 10 The fat, the kidneys, and the lobe of the liver from the sin offering he burned on the altar, as Yahweh had commanded Moses. 11 The flesh and the skin he burned with fire outside the camp. 12 Then he slaughtered the burnt offering. Aaron's sons handed him the blood, and he splashed it all around against the altar. 13 They handed him the burnt offering, piece by piece, with the head, and he burned them on the altar. 14 He washed the entrails and the legs and burned them with the burnt offering on the altar.
15 Then he brought the people's offering, and took the goat which was the sin offering for the people, and killed it and offered it for sin, as the first one. 16 He presented the burnt offering and offered it according to the regulation. 17 He presented the grain offering, took a handful of it, and burned it on the altar, in addition to the burnt offering of the morning. 18 Then he slaughtered the ox and the ram, the sacrifice of peace offerings for the people. Aaron's sons handed him the blood, and he splashed it all around against the altar. 19 And the fat portions of the ox and of the ram, the fat tail, the fat that covers the entrails, the kidneys, and the lobe of the liver, 20 they put the fat portions on the breasts, and he burned the fat portions on the altar. 21 The breasts and the right thigh Aaron lifted up as a wave offering before Yahweh, as Moses had commanded.[b]

22 Then Aaron lifted up his hands toward the people and blessed them.[c]
He came down from offering the sin offering, the burnt offering, and
the peace offerings. 23 Moses and Aaron went into the tent of meeting,
and when they came out they blessed the people, and the glory
of Yahweh appeared to all the people. 24 Fire came out from before
Yahweh and consumed the burnt offering and the fat portions on the
altar. When all the people saw it, they shouted for joy[d] and fell on
their faces.

Notes

- a (9:7) The Septuagint reads "for yourself and for your house," as in 16:6.
- b (9:21) Many Hebrew manuscripts, the Samaritan Pentateuch, and the Septuagint read "as Yahweh had commanded Moses."
- c (9:22) Perhaps with the priestly blessing of Numbers 6:24–26.
- d (9:24) Hebrew ranan, a ringing cry, usually of joy.

Chapter 10

1 Now Nadab[a] and Abihu,[b] the sons of Aaron, each took his censer,
put fire in it, and laid incense on it, and they offered unauthorized[c]
fire before Yahweh, which he had not commanded them. 2 Fire came
out from before Yahweh and consumed them, and they died before
Yahweh. 3 Then Moses said to Aaron, "This is what Yahweh meant
when he said, 'Through those who approach me I will show myself
holy, and before the whole people I will be honored.'" And Aaron held
his peace.
4 Moses called Mishael[d] and Elzaphan,[e] the sons of Uzziel,[f] Aaron's
uncle, and said to them, "Draw near; carry your brothers from before
the sanctuary out of the camp." 5 So they came near and carried them
in their tunics to outside the camp, as Moses had said. 6 Moses said
to Aaron and to his sons Eleazar[g] and Ithamar,[h] "Do not let the hair
of your heads hang loose[i] or tear your garments, or you will die, and
wrath will come on all the congregation. But your brothers, the whole
house of Israel, may weep over the burning that Yahweh has kindled.
7 You must not go out from the entrance of the tent of meeting, or
you will die, for Yahweh's anointing oil is on you." And they did as
Moses said.

8 Yahweh spoke to Aaron, saying, 9 "Drink no wine or strong drink,[j]
you nor your sons with you, whenever you go into the tent of
meeting, or you will die. This is a perpetual statute for all your gener-
ations. 10 You are to distinguish between the holy and the common,
and between the unclean and the clean, 11 and you are to teach the
Israelites all the statutes that Yahweh has spoken to them through
Moses."
12 Moses spoke to Aaron and to Aaron's remaining sons, Eleazar and
Ithamar: "Take what remains of the grain offering from Yahweh's fire
offerings and eat it unleavened beside the altar; for it is most holy. 13
You are to eat it in a holy place, because it is your due and your sons'
due from Yahweh's offerings by fire, for so I have been commanded. 14
But the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the contribution
you shall eat in a clean place, you, your sons, and your daughters
with you; for they are granted to you and to your children as your
portion from the peace offering sacrifices of the Israelites. 15 The thigh
of the contribution and the breast of the wave offering they are to
bring with the offerings by fire of the fat portions, to wave as a wave
offering before Yahweh. It will be yours and your sons' with you as
a due forever, as Yahweh has commanded."
16 Then Moses diligently inquired about the goat of the sin offering,
and behold, it had been burned up. And he was angry with Eleazar
and Ithamar, the remaining sons of Aaron, saying, 17 "Why did you not
eat the sin offering in the holy place, since it is most holy? He gave it
to you to bear the iniquity of the congregation, to make atonement for
them before Yahweh. 18 Its blood was not brought into the sanctuary.
You certainly should have eaten it in the sanctuary, as I commanded."
19 Aaron said to Moses, "See, this very day they have offered their sin
offering and their burnt offering before Yahweh, and yet such things
have befallen me! Had I eaten the sin offering today, would it have
been pleasing in Yahweh's sight?" 20 When Moses heard that, it was
good in his eyes.[k]

Notes

- a (10:1) Nadab means "generous" or "willing."
- b (10:1) Abihu means "he is my father," probably referring to God.

- c (10:1) Hebrew zarah, “strange” or “foreign.” What made the fire wrong is not stated. Suggestions include fire not taken from the altar (compare 16:12), incense offered at the wrong time or place, or drunkenness, given the command in verse 9.
- d (10:4) Mishael means “who is what God is?”
- e (10:4) Elzaphan means “God has protected” or “God has hidden.” He is called Elizaphan in Numbers 3:30.
- f (10:4) Uzziel means “God is my strength.”
- g (10:6) Eleazar means “God has helped.”
- h (10:6) Ithamar may mean “island of palms” or “where is Tamar?”; its meaning is uncertain.
- i (10:6) Or “uncover your heads”; Hebrew para‘, to let the hair go loose or unkempt, a sign of mourning (13:45; 21:10).
- j (10:9) Hebrew shekhar, an intoxicating drink, perhaps beer made from barley.
- k (10:20) Or “he approved.” Since the people’s sin offering (9:15) should have been eaten by the priests (6:26), Aaron may mean that after the deaths of his sons the priests were unfit to eat it, or that the deaths had defiled the sanctuary so that the offering had to be burned.

Chapter 11

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying to them, 2 “Speak
to the Israelites, saying: These are the creatures which you may eat
among all the beasts that are on the earth. 3 Whatever divides the
hoof, having a split hoof, and chews the cud, among the animals, you
may eat. 4 Nevertheless, among those that chew the cud or that have a
divided hoof, these you shall not eat: the camel—it chews the cud but
does not part the hoof; it is unclean to you. 5 And the rock badger,[a]
because it chews the cud yet does not part the hoof, is unclean to you.
6 And the hare, because it chews the cud[b] yet does not part the hoof,
is unclean to you. 7 The pig, because it divides the hoof, having a split
hoof, but does not chew the cud; it is unclean to you. 8 You must not
eat any of their flesh, and you must not touch their carcasses. They
are unclean to you.
9 “These you may eat of everything that lives in the waters: whatever
has fins and scales in the waters, whether in seas or in rivers, you
may eat. 10 But anything in the seas or the rivers that lacks fins and
scales, whether swarming things of the waters or any other living
creature in the waters, is an abomination[c] to you. 11 They are to remain
detestable to you. You must not eat any of their flesh, and you are to

detest their carcasses. 12 Everything in the waters that does not have
fins and scales is detestable to you.
13 "These you are to detest among the birds; they must not be eaten;
they are detestable: the eagle,[d] the bearded vulture, the black vulture,
14 the kite, the falcon of any kind, 15 every raven of any kind, 16 the
ostrich,[e] the nighthawk, the gull, the hawk of any kind, 17 the little
owl, the cormorant, the great owl, 18 the barn owl, the desert owl, the
carrion vulture, 19 the stork, the heron of any kind, the hoopoe, and
the bat.[f]
20 "All winged swarming things that go on all fours[g] are detestable to
you. 21 Yet these you may eat among all the winged swarming things
that go on all fours: those that have jointed legs above their feet, with
which to leap on the earth. 22 Of them you may eat these: the locust
of any kind, the bald locust of any kind, the cricket of any kind, and
the grasshopper of any kind.[h] 23 But all other winged swarming things
that have four feet are detestable to you.
24 "By these you will become unclean. Whoever touches their car-
casses will be unclean until evening. 25 Whoever carries any part of
their carcasses is to wash his clothes and be unclean until evening.
26 Every animal that divides the hoof but does not have a split hoof,
or does not chew the cud, is unclean to you. Everyone who touches
them will be unclean. 27 And whatever walks on its paws, among all
kinds of animals that walk on all fours, is unclean to you; whoever
touches their carcasses shall be unclean until the evening. 28 And he
who carries their carcasses shall wash his clothes and be unclean until
the evening; they are unclean to you.
29 "These are unclean to you among the swarming things that swarm
on the earth: the mole rat,[i] the mouse, the great lizard of any kind, 30
the gecko, the monitor lizard, the wall lizard, the sand lizard, and the
chameleon. 31 Among all the swarming things, these are unclean to
you; whoever touches one of them when it is dead shall be unclean
until the evening. 32 And anything upon which one of them falls when
it is dead shall be unclean—any article of wood, or garment, or skin, or
sack, any vessel used for any work; it shall be put in water and remain
unclean until the evening; after that it shall be clean. 33 And if any of

them falls into an earthen vessel, all that is in it shall be unclean, and you shall break the vessel. 34 Any food that could be eaten, on which water from such a pot comes, will be unclean, and any drink that could be drunk from any such vessel will be unclean. 35 Everything on which any part of their carcass falls will be unclean. Whether oven or stove,[j] it is to be broken down. They are unclean and will remain unclean to you. 36 But a spring or a cistern holding a collection of water will be clean, though whoever touches their carcass will be unclean. 37 And if any part of their carcass falls on any sowing seed that is to be sown, it is clean. 38 But if water is put on the seed and any part of their carcass falls on it, it is unclean to you.

39 "And if any beast of which you may eat dies, he who touches its carcass shall be unclean until the evening. 40 Whoever eats of its carcass is to wash his clothes and be unclean until evening. Whoever carries its carcass is to wash his clothes and be unclean until evening.

41 "And every swarming thing that swarms on the earth is an abomination; it shall not be eaten. 42 Whatever goes on its belly, and whatever goes on all fours, or whatever has many feet, among all the swarming things that swarm on the earth, you must not eat them, for they are detestable. 43 You shall not make yourselves abominable with any swarming thing that swarms; nor shall you make yourselves unclean with them, that you should be defiled by them. 44 For I am Yahweh your God. Consecrate yourselves, therefore, and be holy, for I am holy.[k] You must not defile yourselves with any swarming thing that moves on the earth. 45 For I am Yahweh who brought you up out of the land of Egypt to be your God. You are to be holy, for I am holy."

46 This is the law about animals and birds and every living creature that moves in the waters and every creature that swarms on the earth, 47 to distinguish between the unclean and the clean, and between the living thing that may be eaten and the living thing that may not be eaten.

Notes

- a (11:5) Hebrew shaphan, probably the rock hyrax (Procavia capensis), a small animal of rocky places (Psalm 104:18; Proverbs 30:26).

- b (11:6) The hyrax and the hare do not chew the cud as cattle do, but their constant jaw motion and their habit of re-eating partly digested droppings look like it. The law uses ordinary observation, not modern zoological categories. The Septuagint names these two animals differently, and its wording in verses 5–6 differs from the Hebrew.
- c (11:10) Hebrew sheqets, a stronger word than "unclean," used of things to be avoided with revulsion.
- d (11:13) Hebrew nesher, which can include the griffon vulture. Many of the bird names in verses 13–19 cannot be identified with certainty; the translations given are traditional or probable.
- e (11:16) Or "eagle owl"; Hebrew bath haya'anah, literally "daughter of the desert" or "daughter of greed."
- f (11:19) The bat is grouped with birds because it flies. Hebrew 'oph means any winged creature.
- g (11:20) That is, insects, which walk while seeming to move on four legs.
- h (11:22) The four Hebrew names, 'arbeh, sal'am, chargol, and chagav, are all types of locust or grasshopper whose exact identification is uncertain.
- i (11:29) Hebrew choled, traditionally "weasel," but probably the mole rat. The identification of the creatures in verses 29–30 is uncertain.
- j (11:35) Hebrew kirayim, a word found only here, probably a two-part cooking stove.
- k (11:44) This command, repeated in 11:45, 19:2, and 20:26, is the keynote of Leviticus and is quoted in 1 Peter 1:16.

Chapter 12

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Say to the Israelites: If a woman conceives[a] and gives birth to a boy, she shall be unclean for a week, just as during her monthly impurity[b] she is unclean. 3 On the eighth day the flesh of his foreskin is to be circumcised. 4 Then she is to remain in the blood of her purifying for thirty-three days. She must not touch anything holy or come into the sanctuary until the days of her purifying are completed. 5 But if she gives birth to a female child, she will be unclean two weeks, as in her menstrual impurity, and she is to remain in the blood of her purifying for sixty-six days.[c]

6 "And when the days of her purifying are fulfilled, for a son or for a daughter, she shall bring to the priest a lamb a year old for a burnt offering, and a young pigeon or a turtledove for a sin offering, to the entrance of the tent of meeting. 7 And he shall offer it before Yahweh and make atonement for her, and she shall be clean from the source

of her blood. This is the law for her who bears a child, whether male or female. 8 If she cannot afford a lamb, she is to take two turtledoves or two young pigeons, one for a burnt offering and the other for a sin offering. The priest is to make atonement for her, and she will be clean."[d]

Notes

- a (12:2) Hebrew tazria', literally "produces seed," that is, conceives.
- b (12:2) Hebrew niddah, the separation of menstruation (15:19–24).
- c (12:5) No reason is given for the doubled periods for a daughter. The impurity is ritual, not moral; childbirth itself is not a sin, as the blessing of Genesis 1:28 shows. The sin offering here is better understood as a purification offering (see the note at 4:3).
- d (12:8) Mary offered the offering of the poor after the birth of Jesus (Luke 2:22–24).

Chapter 13

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 2 "When anyone has a swelling, or a scab, or a bright spot in the skin of his flesh, and it develops there into an affliction[a] of defiling skin disease,[b] he shall be brought to Aaron the priest or to one of his sons the priests. 3 The priest is to examine the affliction on the skin of the body. If the hair in the affliction has turned white and the affliction appears deeper than the skin of his body, it is an affliction of a defiling skin disease. When the priest has examined him, he is to pronounce him unclean. 4 But if the bright spot is white in the skin of his flesh, and appears no deeper than the skin, and the hair in it has not turned white, then the priest shall quarantine the afflicted person for seven days. 5 On the seventh day the priest is to examine him, and if in his eyes the affliction has remained as it was and the affliction has not spread on the skin, the priest is to isolate him for another seven days. 6 The priest is to examine him again on the seventh day, and if the affliction has faded and the affliction has not spread on the skin, the priest is to pronounce him clean. It is only a scab. He is to wash his clothes and be clean. 7 But if the scab spreads on the skin after he has shown himself to the priest for his cleansing, he is to show himself to the priest again. 8 The priest is to examine him, and if the scab has spread

on the skin, the priest is to pronounce him unclean. It is a defiling skin disease.
9 “When anyone has an affliction of a defiling skin disease, he is to be
brought to the priest. 10 The priest is to examine him, and if there is a
white swelling on the skin that has turned the hair white, and there is
raw flesh in the swelling, 11 it is a chronic defiling disease on the skin
of his body, and the priest is to pronounce him unclean. He is not to
isolate him, for he is unclean. 12 And if the disease breaks out widely
in the skin, and the disease covers all the skin of the one who has the
affliction, from his head to his foot, wherever the priest looks, 13 then
the priest is to examine him, and if the disease has covered all his
body, he is to pronounce the afflicted person clean.[c] He has turned all
white; he is clean. 14 But whenever raw flesh appears on him, he will
be unclean. 15 And the priest shall look at the raw flesh and pronounce
him unclean; the raw flesh is unclean; it is a defiling skin disease. 16
But if the raw flesh changes again and turns white, he is to come to
the priest. 17 The priest is to examine him, and if the affliction has
turned white, the priest is to pronounce the afflicted person clean. He
is clean.
18 “When there is a boil on the skin of one’s body and it has healed, 19
and in the place of the boil there arises a white swelling or a reddish-
white bright spot, it shall be shown to the priest; 20 The priest is to
examine it, and if it appears lower than the skin and its hair has
turned white, the priest is to pronounce him unclean. It is an affliction
of a defiling skin disease; it has broken out in the boil. 21 But if the
priest examines it and there is no white hair in it, and it is not lower
than the skin but has faded, the priest is to isolate him for seven days.
22 If it spreads on the skin, the priest is to pronounce him unclean.
It is an affliction. 23 But if the bright spot remains where it was and
has not spread, it is only the scar from the boil, and the priest shall
pronounce him clean.
24 “Or if the body receives a burn on its skin, and the raw flesh of
the burn becomes a bright spot, reddish-white or white, 25 the priest
is to examine it, and if the hair in the shiny spot has turned white
and it appears deeper than the skin, it is a defiling skin disease. It has

broken out in the burn, and the priest is to pronounce him unclean. It is an affliction of a defiling skin disease. 26 But if the priest examines it and there is no white hair in the shiny spot, and it is not lower than the skin but has faded, the priest is to isolate him for seven days. 27 The priest is to examine him on the seventh day. If it has spread on the skin, the priest is to pronounce him unclean. It is an affliction of a defiling skin disease. 28 But if the bright spot remains where it was and has not spread in the skin, but has faded, it is the swelling of the burn; the priest shall pronounce him clean, because it is only the scar of the burn.

29 "When a man or a woman has an affliction on the head or the chin, 30 the priest is to examine the affliction, and if it appears deeper than the skin and the hair in it is yellow and thin, the priest is to pronounce him unclean. It is a scaly sore,[d] a defiling skin disease of the head or the chin. 31 And if the priest examines the scale affliction and sees that it appears no deeper than the skin, and no black hair is in it, then the priest shall quarantine the one with the scale affliction for seven days. 32 On the seventh day the priest is to examine the affliction. If the scaly sore has not spread, and there is no yellow hair in it, and the scaly sore does not appear deeper than the skin, 33 then he is to shave himself, but he is not to shave the scaly sore, and the priest is to isolate the person with the scaly sore for another seven days. 34 On the seventh day the priest is to examine the scaly sore. If the scaly sore has not spread on the skin and does not appear deeper than the skin, the priest is to pronounce him clean. He is to wash his clothes and be clean. 35 But if the scaly sore spreads on the skin after his cleansing, 36 the priest is to examine him, and if the scaly sore has spread on the skin, the priest need not look for yellow hair. He is unclean. 37 But if in his eyes the scaly sore has remained as it was and black hair has grown in it, the scaly sore is healed; he is clean, and the priest is to pronounce him clean.

38 "When a man or a woman has shiny spots on the skin of the body, white shiny spots, 39 the priest is to examine them, and if the shiny spots on the skin of their bodies are dull white, it is a harmless rash[e] that has broken out on the skin. He is clean.

40 “If a man loses the hair from his head, he is bald, yet he is clean. 41
If his hair falls out from the front of his head, he has a bald forehead,
but he is clean. 42 But if on the bald head or the bald forehead there
is a reddish-white affliction, it is a defiling skin disease breaking out
on his bald head or his bald forehead. 43 The priest is to examine him,
and if the swelling of the affliction is reddish-white on his bald head
or on his bald forehead, like the appearance of a defiling skin disease
on the skin of the body, 44 he is a man with a defiling skin disease. He
is unclean. The priest must pronounce him unclean; his affliction is
on his head.
45 “The person with the defiling skin disease, who has the affliction,
is to wear torn clothes and let the hair of his head hang loose. He is
to cover his upper lip[f] and cry out, ‘Unclean, unclean!’ 46 He will be
unclean all the days that the affliction is on him. He is unclean. He is
to live alone; his dwelling is to be outside the camp.
47 “When there is an affliction of a defiling mold[g] in a garment,
whether a woolen or a linen garment, 48 in the warp or in the weft[h]
of linen or wool, or in a skin or in anything made of skin, 49 if the
affliction is greenish or reddish in the garment, or in the skin, or in
the warp or the weft, or in any article made of skin, it is an affliction
of a defiling mold, and it is to be shown to the priest. 50 The priest is
to examine the affliction and isolate the thing with the affliction for
seven days. 51 He is to examine the affliction on the seventh day. If the
affliction has spread in the garment, in the warp or the weft, or in the
skin, whatever the use of the skin, the affliction is a malignant[i] mold.
It is unclean. 52 He is to burn the garment, or the warp or the weft,
whether wool or linen, or any article of skin that has the affliction in
it, for it is a malignant mold. It is to be burned in the fire. 53 But if the
priest examines it, and the affliction has not spread in the garment,
in the warp or the weft, or in any article of skin, 54 then the priest is to
command that they wash the thing in which the affliction is, and he
is to isolate it for another seven days. 55 Then the priest shall examine
it after it has been washed; if the affliction has not changed its color,
even though it has not spread, it is unclean; you shall burn it in the
fire, whether the eating away is on the inside or on the outside.[j] 56 If

the priest examines it and the affliction has faded after it was washed, he shall tear it out of the garment, or the leather, or the warp or woof.
57 But if it still appears in the garment, in warp or woof, or in any leather article, it is breaking out again; whatever has the affliction you shall burn with fire. 58 But the garment, the warp or the weft, or any article of skin from which the affliction has gone after you have washed it, is to be washed a second time, and it will be clean."
59 This is the law for an affliction of a defiling mold in a garment of wool or linen, either in the warp or the weft, or in any article of skin, for pronouncing it clean or unclean.

Notes

- a (13:2) Hebrew nega‘, literally "a touch" or "a stroke," a mark or affliction, often thought of as sent by God (compare 14:34).
- b (13:2) Hebrew tsara‘at, traditionally translated "leprosy." It is not Hansen's disease (modern leprosy): the symptoms described here do not match it, there is no clear evidence of Hansen's disease in the ancient Near East before the time of Alexander the Great, and the same word is used for growths on cloth, leather, and the walls of houses (13:47–59; 14:33–53). It covers a range of scaly or flaking skin conditions, possibly including psoriasis, vitiligo, and fungal infections. The Septuagint's lepra (whence "leprosy") means a scaly condition. This translation renders it "defiling skin disease" on people and "defiling mold" on fabrics and houses, the same Hebrew word in both cases.
- c (13:13) The whitening of the whole body apparently showed that the condition had run its course and was no longer active.
- d (13:30) Hebrew netheq, perhaps from a verb meaning "to tear off," a condition of the scalp or beard, perhaps ringworm or a scaly eczema.
- e (13:39) Hebrew bohaq, a word found only here, perhaps a harmless white rash such as vitiligo or leucoderma.
- f (13:45) Or "his mustache," a sign of mourning (Ezekiel 24:17, 22; Micah 3:7).
- g (13:47) Hebrew tsara‘at, the same word used for the skin disease (see the note at 13:2). On cloth and leather it probably means mold, mildew, or a fungus.
- h (13:48) Or possibly "in the woven or knitted material." The exact meaning of the Hebrew shethi and ‘erev is uncertain.
- i (13:51) Hebrew mam'ereth, "malignant" or "painful," a word found only in 13:51–52 and 14:44.
- j (13:55) Literally "whether in its bald back or its bald front," that is, the worn spots on the inside or outside of the fabric. The Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 14

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 “This shall be the law of the one
with a defiling skin disease on the day of his cleansing: He shall be
brought to the priest. 3 The priest is to go out of the camp, and the
priest is to examine him. If the affliction of the defiling skin disease
has been healed in the afflicted person, 4 the priest is to command that
two live clean birds, cedar wood, scarlet yarn, and hyssop[a] be taken
for the one who is to be cleansed. 5 The priest is to command that one
of the birds be slaughtered in a clay pot over running water.[b] 6 As for
the living bird, he shall take it, with the cedar wood and the scarlet
yarn and the hyssop, and dip them and the living bird in the blood
of the bird that was killed over the running water. 7 He shall sprinkle
seven times upon the one to be cleansed from the defiling disease,
then pronounce him clean, and release the living bird into the open
field. 8 The one who is to be cleansed is to wash his clothes, shave off
all his hair, and bathe himself in water, and he will be clean. After that
he may come into the camp, but he is to live outside his tent seven
days. 9 On the seventh day he is to shave off all his hair: his head, his
beard, and his eyebrows. He is to shave off all his hair. Then he is to
wash his clothes and bathe his body in water, and he will be clean.
10 “On the eighth day he is to take two male lambs without defect,
one ewe lamb a year old without defect, about 6 quarts[c] of fine flour
mixed with oil as a grain offering, and about a third of a quart[d] of
oil. 11 The priest who cleanses him is to set the man who is to be
cleansed, with these things, before Yahweh at the entrance of the tent
of meeting. 12 The priest is to take one of the male lambs and offer it
as a guilt offering, with the oil,[e] and wave them as a wave offering
before Yahweh. 13 He shall slaughter the lamb where the sin offering
and the burnt offering are slaughtered, in the sacred place; for the
guilt offering, just like the sin offering, is the priest’s; it is most holy.
14 The priest is to take some of the blood of the guilt offering, and the
priest is to put it on the lobe of the right ear of the one who is to be
cleansed, on the thumb of his right hand, and on the big toe of his
right foot. 15 Then the priest is to take some of the oil and pour it into
the palm of his own left hand. 16 The priest is to dip his right finger

in the oil that is in his left palm and sprinkle some oil with his finger seven times before Yahweh. 17 Of the rest of the oil in his palm, the priest is to put some on the lobe of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed, on the thumb of his right hand, and on the big toe of his right foot, on top of the blood of the guilt offering. 18 What remains of the oil in the priest's hand he shall put on the head of the one being cleansed; and thus the priest shall make atonement for him before Yahweh. 19 The priest is to offer the sin offering and make atonement for the one who is to be cleansed from his uncleanness. After that he is to slaughter the burnt offering. 20 And the priest shall offer the burnt offering together with the grain offering on the altar, and make atonement for him; then he will be clean.

21 "But if he is poor and cannot afford so much, he is to take one male lamb for a guilt offering to be waved, to make atonement for him, and about 2 quarts[f] of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering, and about a third of a quart of oil, 22 and two turtledoves or two young pigeons, whichever he can afford. One is to be a sin offering and the other a burnt offering. 23 On the eighth day he shall bring them for his cleansing to the priest, at the entrance of the tent of meeting, before Yahweh. 24 The priest is to take the lamb of the guilt offering and the oil, and the priest is to wave them as a wave offering before Yahweh. 25 He is to slaughter the lamb of the guilt offering. The priest is to take some of the blood of the guilt offering and put it on the lobe of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed, on the thumb of his right hand, and on the big toe of his right foot. 26 The priest is to pour some of the oil into the palm of his own left hand, 27 And the priest shall sprinkle with his right finger some of the oil that is in his left hand, seven times before Yahweh. 28 And the priest shall put some of the oil that is in his hand on the tip of the right ear of him who is to be cleansed, and on the thumb of his right hand, and on the big toe of his right foot, upon the place of the blood of the guilt offering. 29 And the rest of the oil that is in the priest's hand he shall put on the head of him who is to be cleansed, to make atonement for him before Yahweh. 30 He is to offer one of the turtledoves or young pigeons, whichever he can afford, 31 whatever he can afford,[g] one for a sin offering and

the other for a burnt offering, together with the grain offering. Thus the priest shall make atonement for the one being cleansed, before Yahweh. 32 This is the law for one who has an affliction of a defiling skin disease, who cannot afford the offerings for his cleansing."
33 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 34 "When you come into the land of Canaan,[h] which I am giving you as a possession, and I put an affliction of a defiling mold in a house in the land of your possession, 35 then the one who owns the house shall come and tell the priest, saying, 'It seems to me that there is something like an affliction in the house.' 36 The priest is to command that they empty the house before the priest goes in to examine the affliction, so that nothing in the house becomes unclean. After that the priest is to go in to examine the house. 37 He is to examine the affliction, and if the affliction in the walls of the house has greenish or reddish depressions[i] that appear lower than the surface of the wall, 38 the priest is to go out of the house to the entrance of the house and shut up the house for seven days. 39 The priest is to come again on the seventh day and examine it. If the affliction has spread in the walls of the house, 40 the priest is to command that they tear out the stones in which the affliction is and throw them outside the city in an unclean place. 41 And he shall have the house scraped on the inside all around, and the plaster they scrape off they shall dump into an unclean place outside the city. 42 Then they shall take other stones and put them in the place of those stones, and he shall take other plaster and plaster the house.
43 "But if the affliction comes again and breaks out in the house, after he has taken out the stones, and after he has scraped the house and after it is plastered, 44 the priest is to come and examine it. If the affliction has spread in the house, it is a malignant mold in the house. It is unclean. 45 He shall tear down the house—its stones, its timber, and all its plaster—and carry them outside the city to an unclean place. 46 Moreover, whoever goes into the house while it is shut up will be unclean until evening. 47 And he who lies down in the house shall wash his clothes, and he who eats in the house shall wash his clothes.
48 "But if the priest comes in and examines it, and the affliction has not spread in the house after the house was replastered, the priest

is to pronounce the house clean, because the affliction is healed. [49] To cleanse the house he is to take two birds, cedar wood, scarlet yarn, and hyssop. [50] And he shall kill one of the birds in an earthen vessel over running water. [51] He is to take the cedar wood, the hyssop, the scarlet yarn, and the live bird, and dip them in the blood of the slaughtered bird and in the running water, and sprinkle the house seven times. [52] So he is to cleanse the house with the blood of the bird and with the running water, with the live bird, the cedar wood, the hyssop, and the scarlet yarn. [53] But the living bird he shall release outside the city into the open field, and so he shall make atonement for the house; and it will be clean."

[54] This is the law for every affliction of a defiling skin disease, for a scaly sore, [55] for a defiling mold in a garment or in a house, [56] for a swelling, for a scab, and for a shiny spot, [57] to teach when it is unclean and when it is clean. This is the law for defiling diseases.

Notes

- a (14:4) Hebrew 'ezov, probably the Syrian hyssop or marjoram (Origanum syriacum), whose bushy stems could be used for sprinkling (Exodus 12:22; Psalm 51:7).
- b (14:5) Literally "living water," fresh water from a spring or stream rather than standing water.
- c (14:10) Hebrew "three-tenths of an ephah," about 6.6 liters. Ancient standards varied.
- d (14:10) Hebrew "one log," a liquid measure found in the Bible only in this chapter (14:10, 12, 15, 21, 24). Later Jewish sources make it about a twelfth of a hin, roughly 0.3 liter; the ancient value is uncertain. The Septuagint reads kotyle, "a small cup."
- e (14:12) Hebrew "with the log of oil"; so also in verses 15 and 24, the oil measured out in verse 10.
- f (14:21) Hebrew "one-tenth of an ephah," about 2.2 liters.
- g (14:31) The Septuagint lacks "such as he can afford" at the start of this verse; the Hebrew repeats the phrase from verse 30.
- h (14:34) The name Canaan is of uncertain meaning; it may be related to a word for purple dye (compare Genesis 9:18).
- i (14:37) Hebrew sheqaʿaruroth, a word found only here, perhaps "depressions" or "streaks."

Chapter 15

[1] Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, [2] "Speak to the Israelites and tell them: Any man who has a discharge from his body,[a]

that discharge is unclean. 3 This is his uncleanness in his discharge:
whether his body runs with his discharge or his body is blocked from
his discharge, it is his uncleanness.[b] 4 Every bed on which the one
with the discharge lies will be unclean, and everything on which he
sits will be unclean. 5 Anyone who touches his bed is to wash his
clothes and bathe in water and be unclean until evening. 6 Anyone
who sits on something upon which the man with the discharge sat
shall wash his clothes and bathe in water, and be unclean until the
evening. 7 Whoever touches the body of the one with the discharge is
to wash his clothes and bathe in water and be unclean until evening.
8 If the one with the discharge spits on someone who is clean, that
person is to wash his clothes and bathe in water and be unclean until
evening. 9 Any saddle that the one with the discharge rides on will be
unclean. 10 Anyone who touches anything that was under him shall
be unclean until the evening; whoever picks up such things shall
launder his clothes, bathe in water, and be unclean until the evening.
11 Anyone whom the one with the discharge touches without having
rinsed his hands in water is to wash his clothes and bathe in water and
be unclean until evening. 12 A clay pot that the one with the discharge
touches is to be broken, and every wooden article is to be rinsed in
water.
13 "When the man with the discharge is cleansed of it, he shall count
off seven days for his cleansing, and wash his clothes and bathe his
body in fresh running water, and he shall be clean. 14 On the eighth
day he is to take two turtledoves or two young pigeons and come
before Yahweh to the entrance of the tent of meeting and give them
to the priest. 15 The priest is to offer them, one as a sin offering and
the other as a burnt offering. So the priest is to make atonement for
him before Yahweh for his discharge.
16 "When a man has an emission of semen, he is to bathe his whole
body in water and be unclean until evening. 17 Every garment and
every skin on which there is semen is to be washed with water and be
unclean until evening. 18 When a man lies with a woman and has an
emission of semen, both of them are to bathe in water and be unclean
until evening.

19 “When a woman has a discharge, the discharge from her body being
blood, she shall be in her monthly impurity for seven days, and any-
one who touches her shall be unclean until the evening. 20 Everything
on which she lies during her menstrual impurity will be unclean, and
everything on which she sits will be unclean. 21 Whoever touches her
bed is to wash his clothes and bathe in water and be unclean until
evening. 22 Whoever touches anything on which she sits is to wash his
clothes and bathe in water and be unclean until evening. 23 Whether it
is on the bed or on whatever she was sitting upon, whoever touches
it shall be unclean until the evening. 24 If any man lies with her and
her menstrual impurity comes on him, he will be unclean seven days,
and every bed on which he lies will be unclean.
25 “When a woman has a flow of blood for many days outside the time
of her monthly impurity, or if it continues beyond that time, she shall
be unclean all the days of her unclean discharge, as in the days of her
impurity.[c] 26 Every bed on which she lies all the days of her discharge is
to be to her like the bed of her impurity, and everything on which she
sits will be unclean, like the uncleanness of her impurity. 27 Whoever
touches these things will be unclean and is to wash his clothes and
bathe in water and be unclean until evening. 28 But if she is cleansed
of her discharge, she is to count for herself seven days, and after that
she will be clean. 29 On the eighth day she shall take two turtledoves
or two young pigeons for herself and bring them to the priest at the
entrance of the tent of meeting. 30 Then the priest shall offer the one
as a sin offering and the other as a burnt offering, and the priest
shall make atonement for her before Yahweh for the discharge of her
uncleanness.
31 “So you are to keep the Israelites separate from their uncleanness,
so that they do not die in their uncleanness by defiling my tabernacle
that is among them.”
32 This is the law for the man with a discharge, and for him whose
semen goes out from him so that he is made unclean by it; 33 also
for the woman who is sick with her monthly impurity, for anyone,
male or female, with a discharge, and for a man who lies with an
unclean woman.

Notes

- a (15:2) Literally "from his flesh," a euphemism for the genitals. The discharge is probably an abnormal one, such as from gonorrhea or another infection, not a normal emission (verse 16).
- b (15:3) The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Septuagint, and a Dead Sea Scroll of Leviticus in paleo-Hebrew script (11QpaleoLev-a) add "all the days of the discharge of his body, whether his body runs with his discharge or is blocked by it." The Masoretic Text may have lost the words by a scribe's eye skipping between the similar phrases.
- c (15:25) Compare the woman who had suffered from bleeding for twelve years (Mark 5:25–34).

Chapter 16

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses after the death of the two sons of Aaron,
when they came near before Yahweh and died.[a] 2 Yahweh said to
Moses, "Tell your brother Aaron not to come at all times into the holy
place within the veil, before the mercy seat[b] that is upon the ark, lest
he die; for I will appear in the cloud above the mercy seat. 3 This is
how Aaron is to come into the Holy Place: with a young bull for a
sin offering and a ram for a burnt offering. 4 He shall put on the holy
linen coat, with linen breeches upon his body; he shall be girded with
the linen sash and wear the linen turban. Holy garments are these;
so he shall bathe his body in water and then put them on. 5 And from
the congregation of the Israelites he shall take two male goats for a
sin offering, and one ram for a burnt offering.
6 "Aaron is to offer the bull as a sin offering for himself and make
atonement for himself and for his house. 7 Then he is to take the
two goats and set them before Yahweh at the entrance of the tent of
meeting. 8 Aaron is to cast lots over the two goats, one lot for Yahweh
and the other lot for Azazel.[c] 9 Aaron is to present the goat on which
the lot for Yahweh fell and offer it as a sin offering. 10 But the goat on
which the lot for Azazel fell is to be set alive before Yahweh, to make
atonement over it,[d] to send it away into the wilderness to Azazel.
11 "Aaron shall bring the bull of the sin offering that is for himself, and
make atonement for himself and his household; he shall slaughter the
bull of the sin offering that is for himself. 12 He shall take a censer full
of burning coals from the altar before Yahweh, and a double handful

of sweet incense beaten small, and bring it within the veil. 13 He shall
put the incense on the fire before Yahweh, so the incense cloud will
veil the mercy seat above the testimony,[e] and he will not die. 14 He is
to take some of the blood of the bull and sprinkle it with his finger
on the front of the atonement cover,[f] and before the atonement cover
he is to sprinkle some of the blood with his finger seven times.
15 "Then he shall slaughter the goat of the sin offering for the people
and bring its blood inside the veil; and just as he did with the bull's
blood, he shall do with this blood, sprinkling it upon the mercy seat
and before the mercy seat. 16 Thus he shall make atonement for the
holy place, on account of the uncleannesses of the Israelites and their
rebellions, whatever their sins; and so he shall do for the tent of
meeting, which remains among them in the midst of their uncleanness-
nesses. 17 No one is to be in the tent of meeting from the time he goes
in to make atonement in the Holy Place until he comes out and has
made atonement for himself, for his house, and for all the assembly
of Israel. 18 Then he is to go out to the altar that is before Yahweh and
make atonement for it. He is to take some of the blood of the bull
and some of the blood of the goat and put it on the horns of the altar
all around. 19 He is to sprinkle some of the blood on it with his finger
seven times, and cleanse it and consecrate it from the uncleannesses
of the Israelites.
20 "When he has finished making atonement for the Holy Place, the
tent of meeting, and the altar, he is to present the live goat. 21 Aaron
shall lay both his hands upon the head of the live goat, and confess
over it all the iniquities of the Israelites and all their rebellions,
whatever their sins, putting them upon the goat's head; then by the
hand of a man appointed for the purpose he shall send it away into
the wilderness.[g] 22 The goat will carry on itself all their iniquities to a
remote land,[h] and he is to let the goat go free in the wilderness.
23 "Then Aaron shall come into the tent of meeting, and shall take off
the linen garments which he put on when he went into the holy place,
and shall leave them there. 24 He is to bathe his body in water in a
holy place and put on his garments, and come out and offer his burnt
offering and the burnt offering of the people, and make atonement

for himself and for the people. 25 The fat of the sin offering he is to
burn on the altar. 26 The one who let the goat go to Azazel is to wash
his clothes and bathe his body in water, and after that he may come
into the camp. 27 The bull of the sin offering and the goat of the sin
offering, whose blood was brought in to make atonement in the Holy
Place, are to be carried outside the camp. Their hides, their flesh, and
their dung are to be burned with fire. 28 The one who burns them is to
wash his clothes and bathe his body in water, and after that he may
come into the camp.
29 "This is to be a statute forever for you: in the seventh month (in
September–October),[i] on the tenth day of the month, you are to
humble yourselves[j] and do no work at all, whether the native-born
or the foreigner who resides among you. 30 For on this day atonement
will be made for you, to cleanse you. From all your sins you will be
clean before Yahweh. 31 It is a Sabbath of complete rest[k] for you, and
you are to humble yourselves. It is a statute forever. 32 The priest who
is anointed and installed to serve as priest in place of his father shall
make the atonement, wearing the linen garments, the holy garments;
33 he shall make atonement for the holy sanctuary,[l] and he shall make
atonement for the tent of meeting and for the altar, and he shall make
atonement for the priests and for all the people of the assembly. 34 And
this shall be an everlasting statute for you, that atonement be made
for the Israelites once every year for all their sins." And as Yahweh
commanded Moses, so he did.[m]

Notes

- a (16:1) The Samaritan Pentateuch and the Septuagint read "when they offered strange fire before Yahweh and died," recalling 10:1–2.
- b (16:2) Hebrew kapporeth, from the same root as kipper, "to atone." The traditional "mercy seat" comes from the German of Martin Luther by way of William Tyndale. See the note at Exodus 25:17.
- c (16:8) Hebrew laʿaza'zel, "for Azazel," a word found only in this chapter (verses 8, 10, 26). Its meaning is much debated. (1) A proper name, perhaps of a wilderness demon, matching "for Yahweh" in the same verse; 1 Enoch 8–10 makes Azazel the leader of fallen angels. (2) "The goat that departs," from ʿez, "goat," and 'azal, "go away," the source of the traditional English "scapegoat" (from Tyndale) and close to the Septuagint's apopompaios, "the one sent away," and the Vulgate's caper emissarius. (3) A place name, "a rugged cliff" or "precipice," as in some rabbinic

tradition. (4) An abstract noun meaning "complete removal." The name is kept here as it stands in the Hebrew. In no reading is the goat a sacrifice offered to Azazel; it carries Israel's sins away (verses 21–22).

- d (16:10) Or "to make atonement with it," or "to perform purification on it." The precise sense of kipper here is debated, since the goat is not slaughtered.
- e (16:13) The tablets of the covenant inside the ark (Exodus 25:16, 21).
- f (16:14) Literally "on the face of the atonement cover eastward."
- g (16:21) Hebrew 'itti, a word found only here, perhaps "appointed" or "standing ready." The Septuagint reads "a man ready at hand."
- h (16:22) Hebrew gezerah, literally "cut off," a land from which there is no return.
- i (16:29) Hebrew "in the seventh month," counted from the spring new year of Israel's religious calendar (Exodus 12:2). Because the Hebrew months were lunar, the seventh month (later called Tishri) fell in September–October. This tenth day became Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement (23:26–32).
- j (16:29) Literally "afflict your souls," understood in Jewish tradition as fasting and other self-denial (compare Psalm 35:13; Isaiah 58:3, 5; Acts 27:9, "the Fast").
- k (16:31) Hebrew shabbath shabbathon, a rest of the highest degree.
- l (16:33) Literally "the holy sanctuary."
- m (16:34) Hebrew "and he did," that is, Aaron carried out these instructions when the day came. The Septuagint reads "it shall be done once in the year, as the Lord commanded Moses." Hebrews 9:6–14, 24–28 interprets this day in light of Christ.

Chapter 17

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to Aaron and to his sons
and to all the Israelites and say to them, This is what Yahweh has
commanded: 3 "Any man of the house of Israel who kills an ox, or
a lamb, or a goat, either within the camp or outside it, 4 and does
not bring it to the entrance of the tent of meeting[a] to offer it as an
offering to Yahweh before the tabernacle of Yahweh, bloodguilt will
be counted against that man. He has shed blood, and that man will
be cut off from among his people. 5 This is so that the Israelites may
bring to Yahweh the sacrifices they now make in the open field—
bringing them to the priest at the entrance of the tent of meeting, and
offering them as peace offerings to Yahweh. 6 The priest is to splash
the blood against the altar of Yahweh at the entrance of the tent of
meeting and burn the fat as a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 7 So they will
no longer sacrifice their sacrifices to the goat demons,[b] after whom
they prostitute themselves. This is to be a statute forever for them
throughout their generations.

8 “And you are to say to them, Any man of the house of Israel, or of
the foreigners who reside among them, who offers a burnt offering or
sacrifice 9 and does not bring it to the entrance of the tent of meeting
to offer it to Yahweh, that man will be cut off from his people.
10 “If any man of the house of Israel or of the foreigners who reside
among them eats any blood, I will set my face against that person who
eats blood and will cut him off from among his people. 11 For the life[c]
of the flesh is in the blood; and I have given it to you upon the altar
to make atonement for your souls, for the blood makes atonement by
reason of the life within it.[d] 12 Therefore I said to the Israelites, ‘None
of you shall eat blood, nor shall any stranger who lives among you
eat blood.’ 13 Any man of the Israelites, or of the foreigners who reside
among them, who hunts and catches a wild animal or a bird that may
be eaten is to pour out its blood and cover it with dust. 14 For the life
of every creature is its blood; its blood is its very life;[e] therefore I told
the Israelites, ‘You shall eat the blood of no creature, for the life of
every creature is its blood; whoever eats it shall be cut off.’ 15 “And
every person, whether native or stranger, who eats an animal that
died of itself or was torn by wild beasts shall wash his clothes, bathe
himself in water, and remain unclean until the evening; then he shall
be clean. 16 But if he does not wash them or bathe his body, he will
bear his iniquity.”

Notes

- a (17:4) The Septuagint, the Samaritan Pentateuch, and a Dead Sea Scroll of Leviticus (4QLev-d) add here “to make it a burnt offering or a peace offering to Yahweh, to be accepted as a pleasing aroma, and slaughters it outside, and does not bring it to the entrance of the tent of meeting.” Another scroll, 11QpaleoLev-a, has the shorter text of the Masoretic Text, which is followed here.
- b (17:7) Hebrew se‘irim, literally “hairy ones” or “goats,” here goat-like demons or idols thought to live in the wilderness (Isaiah 13:21; 34:14; 2 Chronicles 11:15). The Septuagint reads “vain things” (idols).
- c (17:11) Hebrew nephesh, “soul,” “life,” or “person”; so throughout verses 11–14.
- d (17:11) Or “makes atonement for the life” or “as a life” (in place of the life). The Hebrew bannephesh can be read “by means of the life” or “in exchange for the life.” Compare Hebrews 9:22.
- e (17:14) The Hebrew of this phrase is difficult, literally “its blood is in its life.”

Chapter 18

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 “Speak to the Israelites and say
to them, I am Yahweh your God. 3 You must not do as they do in the
land of Egypt, where you lived, and you must not do as they do in the
land of Canaan, where I am bringing you. You must not walk in their
statutes. 4 You are to do my judgments and keep my statutes, walking
in them. I am Yahweh your God. 5 You are to keep my statutes and
my judgments; the person who does them will live by them.[a] I am
Yahweh.

6 “None of you is to approach any close relative[b] to uncover
nakedness.[c] I am Yahweh. 7 You shall not uncover your father’s
nakedness, that is, the nakedness of your mother; she is your mother,
and you shall not uncover her nakedness. 8 You must not uncover the
nakedness of your father’s wife; it is your father’s nakedness. 9 You
shall not uncover the nakedness of your sister, whether your father’s
daughter or your mother’s daughter, born in the house or born else-
where. 10 You must not uncover the nakedness of your son’s daughter
or your daughter’s daughter, for their nakedness is your own naked-
ness. 11 The nakedness of the daughter of your father’s wife, who was
born to your father, is your sister’s nakedness; you shall not uncover
it. 12 You must not uncover the nakedness of your father’s sister; she
is your father’s close relative. 13 You must not uncover the nakedness
of your mother’s sister, for she is your mother’s close relative. 14 You
shall not uncover the nakedness of your father’s brother, nor shall
you go near his wife; she is your aunt. 15 You must not uncover the
nakedness of your daughter-in-law. She is your son’s wife; you must
not uncover her nakedness. 16 You must not uncover the nakedness of
your brother’s wife; it is your brother’s nakedness.[d] 17 You must not
uncover the nakedness of a woman and her daughter. You must not
take her son’s daughter or her daughter’s daughter to uncover her
nakedness. They are close relatives; it is depravity.[e] 18 You must not
take a woman as a rival wife to her sister, to uncover her nakedness
while her sister is still alive.[f]

19 “You must not approach a woman to uncover her nakedness
while she is unclean in her menstrual impurity. 20 You must not lie

carnally with your neighbor's wife, to become unclean with her. 21 You must not give any of your offspring to make them pass through[g] to Molech,[h] and so profane the name of your God. I am Yahweh. 22 You must not lie with a male as one lies with a woman; it is an abomination.[i] 23 You must not lie with any animal to become unclean with it, and a woman must not stand before an animal to mate with it; it is a perversion.[j]

24 "Do not defile yourselves by any of these things; for by all of them the nations that I am driving out before you have defiled themselves. 25 The land became unclean, so I punished its iniquity upon it, and the land vomited out its inhabitants. 26 But you are to keep my statutes and my judgments and not do any of these abominations, neither the native-born nor the foreigner who resides among you 27 (for the men of the land, who were there before you, practiced all these abominations, and the land became defiled),[k] 28 lest the land vomit you out also, when you defile it, as it vomited out the nation that was before you. 29 For whoever does any of these abominations, those who do so shall be cut off from among their people. 30 So keep my charge, not doing any of the abominable customs that were done before you, and do not make yourselves unclean by them. I am Yahweh your God."

Notes

- a (18:5) Quoted in Nehemiah 9:29; Ezekiel 20:11; Romans 10:5; Galatians 3:12.
- b (18:6) Literally "flesh of his flesh."
- c (18:6) "Uncover nakedness" is a Hebrew idiom for sexual relations; so throughout this chapter.
- d (18:16) Compare the duty of levirate marriage in Deuteronomy 25:5–10, which applies when the brother has died without a son.
- e (18:17) Hebrew zimmah, a deliberate, shameful wickedness.
- f (18:18) The Hebrew can also be read as banning taking a second wife in general ("a woman in addition to another"), as the Damascus Document of Qumran understood it, but the usual sense is a sister.
- g (18:21) Hebrew leha'abir, "to make pass over," often understood as passing children through fire (2 Kings 23:10) as child sacrifice. The Septuagint reads "to serve a ruler."
- h (18:21) Hebrew molek, probably a deity to whom children were sacrificed, though some scholars take it as the name of a kind of sacrifice. The vowels may be those of bosheth, "shame," added to the consonants of melek, "king." The Septuagint here reads archon, "ruler," and elsewhere (20:2) Moloch.

- i (18:22) Hebrew to'evah, something detestable or abhorrent; so in verses 26–30.
- j (18:23) Hebrew tevel, "confusion," a mixing of what should be kept apart.
- k (18:27) A Dead Sea Scroll of Leviticus (11QpaleoLev-a) sets this verse off with marks resembling parentheses, as this translation also does.

Chapter 19

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the whole congregation
of the Israelites and tell them: Holy you shall be, for I, Yahweh your
God, am holy.[a] 3 Each of you is to revere his mother and his father,
and you are to keep my Sabbaths. I am Yahweh your God. 4 Do not
turn to worthless idols[b] or make for yourselves gods of cast metal. I
am Yahweh your God.
5 "When you sacrifice a sacrifice of peace offerings to Yahweh, sacri-
fice it so that you are accepted. 6 It shall be eaten the same day you
offer it, or on the next day; and anything left until the third day shall
be burned in the fire. 7 If it is eaten at all on the third day, it is a foul
thing;[c] it will not be accepted. 8 Whoever eats it will bear his iniquity,
because he has profaned what is holy to Yahweh, and that person will
be cut off from his people.
9 "When you reap the harvest of your land, you must not reap to the
very edge of your field, and you must not gather the gleanings of
your harvest. 10 And you shall not glean your vineyard, nor gather the
fallen fruit of your vineyard; you shall leave them for the poor and
the stranger: I am Yahweh your God.
11 "You must not steal, you must not deceive, and you must not lie to
one another. 12 You shall not swear falsely by my name, so profaning
the name of your God: I am Yahweh.
13 "You must not oppress your neighbor or rob him. The wages of a
hired worker must not remain with you all night until morning. 14 You
shall not curse the deaf, nor put a stumbling block in the path of the
blind, but you shall fear your God: I am Yahweh.
15 "You must not do injustice in judgment. You must not show partial-
ity to the poor or defer to the great. In righteousness you are to judge
your neighbor. 16 You must not go around as a slanderer among your
people. You must not stand against the blood[d] of your neighbor. I am
Yahweh.

17 “You must not hate your brother in your heart. You are to reprove
your neighbor plainly, so that you do not bear sin because of him.[e] 18
You shall not take revenge, nor hold a grudge against your people’s
children, but you shall love your neighbor as yourself:[f] I am Yahweh.
19 “You are to keep my statutes. You must not let your livestock breed
with another kind. You must not sow your field with two kinds of
seed, nor put on a garment made of two kinds of material.[g]
20 “If a man lies sexually with a woman who is a slave, promised to
another man[h] and not yet ransomed or given her freedom, there shall
be punishment.[i] They shall not be put to death, since she was not
free. 21 He is to bring his guilt offering to Yahweh, to the entrance of
the tent of meeting, a ram as a guilt offering. 22 The priest is to make
atonement for him with the ram of the guilt offering before Yahweh
for his sin that he has committed, and he will be forgiven for the sin
that he has committed.
23 “When you enter the land and plant fruit trees of any kind, you
shall regard their fruit as uncircumcised.[j] For three years it shall be
uncircumcised to you; it must not be eaten. 24 In the fourth year all its
fruit is to be holy, an offering of praise to Yahweh. 25 But in the fifth
year you may eat its fruit, so that it may increase its yield for you. I
am Yahweh your God.
26 “You must not eat anything with the blood.[k] You must not practice
divination or soothsaying.[l] 27 You must not cut off the hair at the sides
of your head or mar the edges of your beard. 28 You must not make
any cuts in your flesh for the dead or put tattoo marks on yourselves.
I am Yahweh.
29 Do not profane your daughter by making her a harlot, or the land
will fall into harlotry and be filled with wickedness. 30 You are to keep
my Sabbaths and revere my sanctuary. I am Yahweh.
31 “Do not turn to mediums or to spiritists;[m] do not seek them out to
be made unclean by them. I am Yahweh your God.
32 “You are to rise up before the gray head and honor the face of an
old man, and you are to fear your God. I am Yahweh.
33 “When a foreigner resides with you in your land, you must not
mistreat him. 34 The foreigner who resides with you is to be to you

like the native-born among you, and you are to love him as yourself, for you were foreigners in the land of Egypt. I am Yahweh your God.
35 "You must not do injustice in judgment, in measurement of length, weight, or quantity. 36 You are to have honest scales, honest weights, an honest dry measure, and an honest liquid measure.[n] I am Yahweh your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt. 37 You are to keep all my statutes and all my judgments and do them. I am Yahweh."

Notes

- a (19:2) Quoted in 1 Peter 1:16.
- b (19:4) Hebrew 'elilim, "nothings" or "worthless things," a scornful word for idols that sounds like 'elohim, "gods."
- c (19:7) Hebrew piggul, meat that has become ritually offensive; see the note at 7:18.
- d (19:16) That is, do nothing that endangers your neighbor's life, whether by false testimony or by standing idle. The Hebrew is difficult.
- e (19:17) Or "so that you do not incur sin on his account" (by letting him go on in it).
- f (19:18) Quoted by Jesus as the second great commandment (Matthew 22:39; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27), and in Romans 13:9; Galatians 5:14; James 2:8.
- g (19:19) Hebrew sha'atnez, a word of uncertain, perhaps foreign, origin; Deuteronomy 22:11 explains it as wool and linen together.
- h (19:20) Or "betrothed to another man." The Hebrew neḥerepheth occurs only here.
- i (19:20) Hebrew biqqoreth, found only here; perhaps "an inquiry," "compensation," or "punishment." The Septuagint reads "they shall be visited with punishment."
- j (19:23) Literally "you are to regard its foreskin as its foreskin," that is, as uncircumcised; so later in the verse.
- k (19:26) Or "over the blood," perhaps a rite at the place of slaughter. The Septuagint reads "on the mountains."
- l (19:26) Two kinds of forbidden divination; the exact practices are uncertain.
- m (19:31) Hebrew 'oboth and yidde'onim, those who consult the spirits of the dead and those who claim special knowledge. The exact meanings are uncertain.
- n (19:36) Hebrew "an honest ephah and an honest hin." The ephah was a dry measure of about 3/5 bushel (about 22 liters), and the hin a liquid measure of about 1 gallon (about 3.7 liters). Both stand here for all measures of volume.

Chapter 20

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Say to the Israelites, Any man of the Israelites, or of the foreigners who reside in Israel, who gives any of his offspring to Molech[a] is surely to be put to death. The people

of the land are to stone him with stones. 3 I myself will set my face
against that man and cut him off from among his people, because
he has given some of his offspring to Molech, to make my sanctuary
unclean and to profane my holy name. 4 "And if the people of the land
should shut their eyes to that man who gives one of his children to
Molech, and do not kill him, 5 then I myself will set my face against
that man and his clan, and I will cut off from among their people both
him and everyone who goes whoring after him to play the harlot with
Molech.
6 "The person who turns to mediums and spiritists, to prostitute
himself after them, I will set my face against that person and cut him
off from among his people. 7 Consecrate yourselves, then, and be holy,
for I am Yahweh your God. 8 Keep my statutes and do them. I am
Yahweh who makes you holy.
9 "For anyone who curses his father or his mother shall surely be put
to death; he has cursed his father or his mother, and his blood shall
be upon him.[b]
10 "If a man commits adultery with the wife of a man, if he commits
adultery with the wife of his neighbor,[c] both the adulterer and the
adulteress are surely to be put to death. 11 If a man lies with his father's
wife, he has uncovered his father's nakedness. Both of them are
surely to be put to death; their blood is on them. 12 If a man lies with
his daughter-in-law, both of them are surely to be put to death. They
have committed a perversion; their blood is on them. 13 If a man lies
with a male as one lies with a woman, both of them have committed
an abomination. They are surely to be put to death; their blood is on
them. 14 If a man takes a woman and her mother, it is depravity. He and
they are to be burned with fire, so that there is no depravity among
you. 15 If a man lies with a beast, he shall surely be put to death, and
you shall slay the beast. 16 If a woman approaches any animal to mate
with it, you are to kill the woman and the animal. They are surely to
be put to death; their blood is on them.
17 "If a man takes his sister, his father's daughter or his mother's
daughter, and sees her nakedness and she sees his nakedness, it is
a disgrace,[d] and they are to be cut off in the sight of the children of

their people. He has uncovered his sister's nakedness; he will bear his iniquity. 18 If a man lies with a woman while she is sick and uncovers her nakedness, he has exposed her fountain, and she has uncovered the fountain of her blood; both of them shall be cut off from among their people. 19 You shall not uncover the nakedness of your mother's sister, nor of your father's sister, for that is to expose a near relative; they shall bear their guilt. 20 If a man lies with his uncle's wife, he has uncovered his uncle's nakedness; they shall bear their sin, and shall die without children. 21 If a man takes his brother's wife, it is impurity.[e] He has uncovered his brother's nakedness; they will be childless.

22 "You are to keep all my statutes and all my judgments and do them, so that the land where I am bringing you to live does not vomit you out. 23 You must not walk in the statutes of the nation that I am driving out before you, for they did all these things, and I loathed them. 24 But I have said to you, You will possess their land, and I will give it to you to possess, a land flowing with milk and honey. I am Yahweh your God, who has set you apart from the peoples. 25 You shall therefore make a distinction between clean beasts and unclean, and between unclean birds and clean; and you shall not make yourselves abominable by beast or by bird, or by anything with which the ground teems, which I have separated from you as unclean. 26 You are to be holy to me, for I, Yahweh, am holy, and I have set you apart from the peoples to be mine.

27 "A man or a woman who is a medium or a spiritist[f] is surely to be put to death. They are to stone them with stones; their blood is on them."

Notes

- a (20:2) See the note at 18:21. Here the Septuagint reads Moloch.
- b (20:9) That is, he is responsible for his own death; so throughout this chapter.
- c (20:10) The repeated clause is often taken as an accidental duplication in copying. The Septuagint reads "Whoever commits adultery with the wife of a man, or whoever commits adultery with the wife of his neighbor."
- d (20:17) Hebrew ḥesed, usually "steadfast love," here in a rare negative sense, "shame."
- e (20:21) Hebrew niddah, the word used for menstrual impurity.
- f (20:27) Literally "in whom there is a medium ('ov) or a spirit of knowing." See the note at 19:31.

Chapter 21

1 Yahweh said to Moses, "Speak to the priests, the sons of Aaron, and
say to them, No one is to make himself unclean for a dead person
among his people, 2 except for his close relatives:[a] his mother, his
father, his son, his daughter, his brother, 3 also for his virgin sister who
is near him, who has had no husband; for her he may defile himself. 4
He shall not defile himself as a chief man among his people, profaning
himself.[b] 5 They must not make bald spots on their heads, or shave
off the edges of their beards, or make any cuts in their flesh. 6 They
shall be holy to their God and not profane their God's name; for they
present Yahweh's fire offerings, the bread[c] of their God, and so they
shall be holy. 7 They must not marry a woman who is a prostitute
or who has been defiled,[d] nor marry a woman divorced from her
husband, for the priest is holy to his God. 8 You shall sanctify him,
therefore, for he offers the bread of your God; he shall be holy to you,
for I, Yahweh, who sanctify you, am holy. 9 If the daughter of any
priest profanes herself by prostitution, she profanes her father; she is
to be burned with fire.

10 "The priest who is greatest among his brothers, on whose head the
anointing oil has been poured and who has been ordained to wear
the garments, must not let the hair of his head hang loose or tear
his clothes. 11 He must not go in to any dead body or make himself
unclean even for his father or his mother. 12 nor shall he go out of the
sanctuary, nor profane the sanctuary of his God; for the crown of the
anointing oil of his God is upon him: I am Yahweh. 13 He is to take
a wife in her virginity. 14 A widow, a divorced woman, or one who
has been defiled as a prostitute, these he must not marry. He is to
take as his wife a virgin from his own people, 15 so that he does not
profane his offspring among his people, for I am Yahweh who makes
him holy."

16 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 17 "Speak to Aaron and say, None
of your offspring throughout their generations who has a defect may
approach to offer the food of his God. 18 For any man who has a
blemish shall not draw near: a blind man, or a lame man, or one who
has a flat nose,[e] or any limb too long, 19 or a man who has a fractured

foot or fractured hand, 20 or is a hunchback or a dwarf,[f] or has a spot
in his eye, or eczema or scabs, or crushed testicles. 21 No man among
the descendants of Aaron the priest who has a blemish may approach
to offer Yahweh's fire offerings; because he has a blemish, he may not
draw near to offer the bread of his God. 22 He may eat the food of his
God, both of the most holy and of the holy things, 23 but he must not
go in to the veil or approach the altar, because he has a defect, so that
he does not profane my holy places,[g] for I am Yahweh who makes
them holy." 24 So Moses spoke to Aaron and to his sons and to all the
Israelites.

Notes

- a (21:2) Literally "his flesh who is near to him."
- b (21:4) The Hebrew is difficult, literally "a husband (or master) must not make himself unclean among his people." It may mean that a priest must not defile himself for the relatives of his wife, or that as a leader among his people he must not defile himself. The Septuagint reads "He shall not defile himself suddenly among his people."
- c (21:6) Literally "bread"; so throughout this chapter and the next.
- d (21:7) Or "a woman who has been violated." The Hebrew ḥalalah means "profaned."
- e (21:18) Hebrew ḥarum, perhaps "with a split nose" or a similar facial deformity; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (21:20) Or "emaciated." The meanings of several terms in this verse are uncertain.
- g (21:23) Or "my sanctuaries." The Septuagint reads "the sanctuary of his God."

Chapter 22

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to Aaron and to his sons, so
that they keep themselves apart[a] from the holy things of the Israelites,
which they consecrate to me, and do not profane my holy name. I
am Yahweh. 3 Say to them, If any man among all your offspring
throughout your generations approaches the holy things that the
Israelites consecrate to Yahweh while he has his uncleanness on him,
that person will be cut off from my presence. I am Yahweh. 4 Any
man among Aaron's descendants who has a defiling skin disease[b]
or a discharge may not eat the holy offerings until he is clean. Also
whoever touches anything defiled by a corpse, or a man who has an
emission of semen, 5 or a man who touches any swarming thing by

which he is made unclean, or a person by whom he is made unclean, whatever his uncleanness may be, 6 the person who touches any such thing will be unclean until evening and must not eat of the holy things unless he has bathed his body in water. 7 When the sun is down he becomes clean, and then he may eat of the holy offerings, for it is his food. 8 He must not eat what dies by itself or what is torn by beasts, becoming unclean by it. I am Yahweh. 9 They are to keep my charge, so that they do not bear sin for it and die by it when they profane it. I am Yahweh who makes them holy.
10 "No outsider[c] may eat a holy thing. A priest's guest or a hired worker may not eat a holy thing. 11 But if a priest buys a person with his money, that one may eat of it, and those born in his house may eat of his food. 12 If a priest's daughter marries a layman, she may not eat of the contribution of the holy gifts. 13 But if a priest's daughter is a widow or divorced, and has no children, and returns to her father's house as in her youth, she may eat her father's food; yet no layman shall eat it. 14 If a man eats a holy thing unintentionally, he is to add a fifth of its value to it and give the holy thing to the priest. 15 The priests must not profane the holy things of the Israelites that they contribute to Yahweh, 16 and so cause them to bear iniquity requiring a guilt offering[d] when they eat their holy things, for I am Yahweh who makes them holy."
17 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 18 "Speak to Aaron and to his sons and to all the Israelites and say to them, Any man of the house of Israel, or of the foreigners in Israel, who presents his offering, whether for any of their vows or any of their freewill offerings that they present to Yahweh as a burnt offering, 19 for you to be accepted, it shall be a male without blemish, of the cattle, of the sheep, or of the goats. 20 You must not present anything that has a defect, for it will not be accepted for you. 21 And whoever offers a sacrifice of peace offerings to Yahweh to fulfill a vow[e] or as a freewill offering, from the herd or from the flock, shall offer it without blemish to be accepted; there shall be no blemish in it. 22 Anything blind, broken, or maimed, or having a running sore, scurvy, or scabs, you shall not offer to Yahweh, nor make any of them a fire offering on the altar to

Yahweh. 23 You may offer as a freewill offering an ox or a lamb that has an extra or a stunted limb,[f] but for a vow it shall not be accepted. 24 Anything with its testicles bruised, crushed, torn, or cut you must not present to Yahweh; you must not do this in your land. 25 Nor may you present any of these as the food of your God from the hand of a foreigner. Because their corruption is in them, there is a defect in them; they will not be accepted for you."
26 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 27 "When an ox or a sheep or a goat is born, it is to remain seven days with its mother, and from the eighth day on it will be accepted as an offering by fire to Yahweh. 28 But whether it is an ox or a sheep, you must not slaughter it and its young on the same day. 29 When you sacrifice a sacrifice of thanksgiving to Yahweh, sacrifice it so that you are accepted. 30 It must be eaten the very same day; you shall not leave any of it until morning: I am Yahweh.
31 "So you are to keep my commandments and do them. I am Yahweh. 32 You must not profane my holy name, so that I may be treated as holy among the Israelites. I am Yahweh who makes you holy, 33 who brought you out of the land of Egypt to be your God. I am Yahweh."

Notes

- a (22:2) Or "deal carefully with." The Hebrew nazar is related to nazir, "Nazirite," one set apart.
- b (22:4) Hebrew tsara'at; see the note at 13:2. The Septuagint reads lepra; the condition is not modern leprosy (Hansen's disease).
- c (22:10) Hebrew zar, "stranger," here anyone who is not of a priestly family.
- d (22:16) Hebrew 'awon 'ashmah, "iniquity of guilt"; see the note on 'asham at 5:6.
- e (22:21) Or "a special vow." The Hebrew lephalle' means "to set apart" or "to make extraordinary."
- f (22:23) Hebrew sarua' weqalut, probably "deformed or stunted." The Septuagint reads "with the ears cut off, or that has lost its tail."

Chapter 23

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and say to them, The appointed feasts[a] of Yahweh that you are to proclaim as holy convocations, these are my appointed feasts.

3 “Six days work may be done, but on the seventh day is a Sabbath of
complete rest, a holy convocation. You must not do any work; it is a
Sabbath to Yahweh in all your dwellings.
4 “These are the appointed feasts of Yahweh, the holy convocations
that you are to proclaim at their appointed times. 5 In the first month
(in March–April),[b] on the fourteenth day of the month, at twilight,[c]
is Yahweh’s Passover.[d] 6 On the fifteenth day of the same month is
the Feast of Unleavened Bread to Yahweh. For seven days you are
to eat unleavened bread. 7 On the first day you shall hold a holy
convocation; you shall do no ordinary work.[e] 8 But you shall present
a fire offering to Yahweh for seven days; on the seventh day there is
a holy convocation; you shall do no ordinary work.”
9 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 10 “Speak to the Israelites and say to
them: When you enter the land which I give you and reap its harvest,
then you shall bring the sheaf[f] of the firstfruits of your harvest to the
priest. 11 He shall wave the sheaf before Yahweh for your acceptance;
on the day after the Sabbath[g] the priest shall wave it. 12 And on the
day you wave the sheaf, you shall offer a one-year-old male lamb,
perfect and unblemished, as a burnt offering to Yahweh, 13 and its
grain offering, about 4 quarts[h] of fine flour mixed with oil, an offering
by fire to Yahweh, a pleasing aroma, and its drink offering of wine,
about 1 quart.[i] 14 You shall eat neither bread nor roasted grain nor
fresh heads until that same day, until you have brought the offering
to your God; it shall be a statute forever throughout your generations
in all your dwellings.
15 “You are to count for yourselves from the day after the Sabbath,
from the day you brought the sheaf of the wave offering, seven full
Sabbaths.[j] 16 You are to count fifty days to the day after the seventh
Sabbath.[k] Then you are to present a new grain offering to Yahweh. 17
From your dwellings you are to bring two loaves of bread for a wave
offering, made of about 4 quarts[l] of fine flour. They are to be baked
with leaven, as firstfruits to Yahweh. 18 Along with the bread you
shall present seven lambs one year old, perfect and unblemished, one
young bull, and two rams; they shall be a burnt offering to Yahweh,
with their grain offering and their drink offerings, a fire offering of

pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 19 You are to offer one male goat as a
sin offering and two male lambs a year old as a sacrifice of peace
offerings. 20 The priest is to wave them with the bread of the firstfruits
as a wave offering before Yahweh, with the two lambs. They are to be
holy to Yahweh for the priest. 21 And on this very day you shall make
a proclamation: it shall be a holy convocation for you; you shall do
no ordinary work on it. It is a statute forever in all your dwellings
throughout your generations.
22 "When you harvest your land, do not reap right up to the corners
of your field, and do not collect the gleanings of your harvest; leave
them for the poor and the stranger: I am Yahweh your God."
23 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 24 "Speak to the Israelites, saying, In
the seventh month (in September–October),[m] on the first day of the
month, you are to have a complete rest, a memorial proclaimed with
a blast of horns,[n] a holy convocation. 25 You must not do any ordinary
work, and you are to present an offering by fire to Yahweh."
26 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 27 "But on the tenth day of this
seventh month (in September–October)[o] is the Day of Atonement.[p] It
is to be a holy convocation for you. You are to humble yourselves[q] and
present an offering by fire to Yahweh. 28 You must not do any work
on this very day, for it is a day of atonement, to make atonement for
you before Yahweh your God. 29 For any person who does not humble
himself on this very day will be cut off from his people. 30 And any
person who does any work on this very day, I will destroy that person
from among his people. 31 You shall do no work at all; it is a statute
forever throughout your generations in all your dwellings. 32 It is to be
a Sabbath of complete rest for you, and you are to humble yourselves.
On the ninth day of the month at evening,[r] from evening to evening,
you are to keep your Sabbath."
33 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 34 "Speak to the Israelites, saying,
On the fifteenth day of this seventh month (in September–October)[s]
is the Feast of Booths[t] for seven days to Yahweh. 35 On the first day
is a holy convocation; you must not do any ordinary work. 36 Seven
days you shall present fire offerings to Yahweh. The eighth day shall

be a holy convocation for you, and you shall present a fire offering to Yahweh; it is a sacred assembly,[u] and you shall do no ordinary work.
37 "These are the appointed feasts of Yahweh that you are to proclaim as holy convocations, for presenting offerings by fire to Yahweh: burnt offerings and grain offerings, sacrifices and drink offerings, each on its own day, 38 besides the Sabbaths of Yahweh, and besides your gifts, besides all your vows, and besides all your freewill offerings that you give to Yahweh.
39 "Also, on the fifteenth day of the seventh month (in September–October),[v] when you have gathered in the produce of the land, you shall keep Yahweh's feast for seven days: the first day is a sabbath-rest, and the eighth day is a sabbath-rest. 40 On the first day you shall take for yourselves the fruit of splendid trees,[w] palm fronds, branches of leafy trees, and willows from the brook; and for seven days you shall rejoice before Yahweh your God. 41 You shall keep this as a feast to Yahweh for seven days each year. This is a perpetual statute for your generations: you shall celebrate it in the seventh month. 42 You are to live in booths for seven days. Every native-born Israelite is to live in booths, 43 that your descendants may know that I had the Israelites dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt: I am Yahweh your God." 44 So Moses declared the appointed feasts of Yahweh to the Israelites.

Notes

- a (23:2) Hebrew moʿadim, "appointed times," the fixed festivals of the year.
- b (23:5) Hebrew "in the first month." The months are counted from the spring new year of Israel's religious calendar (Exodus 12:2). This month was called Abib ("ripe grain," Exodus 13:4) and later Nisan (Esther 3:7). Because the Hebrew months were lunar, with an extra month added in some years, the first month did not match a modern month exactly but fell in March–April.
- c (23:5) Hebrew ben haʿarbayim, literally "between the two evenings," the time between sunset and full dark (or, in later practice, between midafternoon and sunset). See the note at Exodus 12:6.
- d (23:5) Hebrew pesaḥ, from pasaḥ, "to pass over" (Exodus 12:13, 23, 27).
- e (23:7) Literally "work of labor," that is, one's regular occupational work, as distinct from preparing food (compare Exodus 12:16).
- f (23:10) Hebrew ʿomer, a sheaf of grain, here the first sheaf of the barley harvest. Elsewhere the same word is a dry measure (Exodus 16:36).

- g (23:11) Which Sabbath is meant was debated in ancient Judaism. The Pharisees and later rabbis took it as the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread (the Septuagint here reads "the day after the first day"), while the Sadducees and others took it as the weekly Sabbath during the feast, so that the count always began on a Sunday.
- h (23:13) Hebrew "two tenths," that is, two tenths of an ephah, about 4.4 liters.
- i (23:13) Hebrew "a fourth of a hin," about 0.9 liter.
- j (23:15) Or "seven full weeks."
- k (23:16) This day, the Feast of Weeks (Exodus 34:22; Deuteronomy 16:10), is called in Greek Pentecost, "fiftieth" (Acts 2:1).
- l (23:17) Hebrew "two tenths," that is, two tenths of an ephah, about 4.4 liters.
- m (23:24) Hebrew "in the seventh month," counted from the spring new year; later called Tishri (1 Kings 8:2 calls it Ethanim). Because the Hebrew months were lunar, it fell in September–October. In later Judaism this first day became Rosh Hashanah, the civil New Year.
- n (23:24) Hebrew teruʿah, a shout or blast, usually understood as the sounding of the shofar (ram's horn). The Septuagint reads "a memorial of trumpets."
- o (23:27) Hebrew "the tenth day of this seventh month" (Tishri); see the note at verse 24.
- p (23:27) Hebrew yom hakkippurim, "day of atonements," Yom Kippur. See chapter 16.
- q (23:27) Literally "afflict your souls"; see the note at 16:29. So in verses 29 and 32.
- r (23:32) Since the Hebrew day began at sunset, the observance runs from the evening that ends the ninth day to the evening of the tenth.
- s (23:34) Hebrew "the fifteenth day of this seventh month" (Tishri); see the note at verse 24.
- t (23:34) Hebrew sukkoth, "booths" or "huts," temporary shelters of branches. Traditionally the Feast of Tabernacles.
- u (23:36) Hebrew ʿatsereth, perhaps "closing assembly." The Septuagint reads "a time of release."
- v (23:39) Hebrew "the fifteenth day of the seventh month" (Tishri); see the note at verse 24.
- w (23:40) Hebrew ʿets hadar, "splendid trees," identified in Jewish tradition as the citron (etrog).

Chapter 24

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Command the Israelites that they
bring you pure oil from beaten olives for the light, so that a lamp
may burn[a] continually. 3 Outside the veil of the testimony in the tent
of meeting, Aaron is to arrange it from evening to morning before
Yahweh continually. It is a statute forever throughout your genera-

tions. 4 He is to arrange the lamps on the lampstand of pure gold[b]
before Yahweh continually.
5 "You are to take fine flour and bake twelve loaves[c] from it; each loaf
is to be made of about 4 quarts.[d] 6 You are to set them in two rows, six
to a row,[e] on the table of pure gold before Yahweh. 7 You are to put
pure frankincense on each row, so that it may be a memorial portion[f]
for the bread, an offering by fire to Yahweh. 8 Every Sabbath day he is
to arrange it before Yahweh continually. It is from the Israelites as a
covenant forever. 9 It is to belong to Aaron and his sons, and they are
to eat it in a holy place, for it is most holy for him from the offerings
by fire to Yahweh, a perpetual due."
10 Now the son of an Israelite woman, whose father was an Egyptian,
went out among the Israelites, and the son of the Israelite woman
and an Israelite man fought in the camp. 11 The son of the Israelite
woman blasphemed the Name[g] and cursed. So they brought him to
Moses. His mother's name was Shelomith,[h] the daughter of Dibri,[i] of
the tribe of Dan.[j] 12 They put him in custody until the will of Yahweh
should be made clear to them.
13 Then Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 14 "Bring the one who cursed
outside the camp, and let all who heard him lay their hands on his
head, and let all the congregation stone him. 15 And speak to the
Israelites, saying, Anyone who curses his God will bear his sin. 16
Whoever blasphemes Yahweh's name shall surely be put to death; the
whole congregation shall stone him. Stranger or native-born, when
he blasphemes the Name, he shall be put to death.
17 "Whoever strikes down any human life is surely to be put to death.
18 Whoever strikes down the life of an animal is to make it good, life
for life. 19 If a man injures his neighbor, as he has done, so it shall be
done to him— 20 fracture for fracture, eye for eye, tooth for tooth.[k]
As he has caused a disfigurement in a person, so is it to be done
to him. 21 Whoever kills an animal is to make it good, and whoever
kills a person is to be put to death. 22 You are to have one standard of
judgment for the foreigner and for the native-born, for I am Yahweh
your God." 23 Then Moses spoke to the Israelites, and they took the

blasphemer outside the camp and stoned him to death with stones. Thus the Israelites did as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

Notes

- a (24:2) Literally "to cause a lamp to go up."
- b (24:4) Literally "the pure lampstand," that is, the lampstand of pure gold (Exodus 25:31).
- c (24:5) Or "twelve rings of bread," the bread of the Presence (Exodus 25:30).
- d (24:5) Hebrew "two tenths," that is, two tenths of an ephah, about 4.4 liters.
- e (24:6) Or "in two piles, six to a pile."
- f (24:7) Hebrew 'azkarah; see the note at 2:2.
- g (24:11) Hebrew hashshem, "the Name," that is, the name Yahweh (verse 16). From this passage comes the Jewish practice of saying HaShem, "the Name," in place of the divine name. The Septuagint reads "named the Name."
- h (24:11) Shelomith means "peaceful," from shalom, "peace." The Septuagint spells it Salomith.
- i (24:11) Dibri perhaps means "talkative" or "my word." The Septuagint spells it Dabri.
- j (24:11) Dan means "judge" (Genesis 30:6).
- k (24:20) This principle of equivalent justice (lex talionis) set a limit on punishment and was applied by judges, not by private revenge. Compare Exodus 21:23–25; Deuteronomy 19:21; Matthew 5:38–39.

Chapter 25

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses on Mount Sinai, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and tell them: When you enter the land that I am giving you, the land shall observe a sabbath to Yahweh. 3 For six years you are to sow your field, and for six years you are to prune your vineyard and gather in its produce. 4 But in the seventh year there is to be a Sabbath of complete rest for the land, a Sabbath to Yahweh. You must not sow your field or prune your vineyard. 5 What grows of itself after your harvest you shall not reap, and you shall not gather the grapes of your unpruned vine;[a] for the land it shall be a year of complete rest.
6 The Sabbath produce of the land will be food for you: for yourself, for your male and female slaves, for your hired worker, and for the resident alien who lives with you, 7 and for your livestock and for the wild animals in your land. All its produce is to be for food.
8 "You are to count seven Sabbaths of years, seven times seven years, so that the time of the seven Sabbaths of years amounts to forty-nine

years. 9 Then on the tenth day of the seventh month (in September–
October)[b] you are to sound the loud horn.[c] On the Day of Atonement
you are to sound the horn throughout all your land. 10 You shall
consecrate the fiftieth year and proclaim liberty[d] in the land for all
its inhabitants. It shall be a jubilee[e] for you: every one of you shall
go back to his property, and every one of you to his family. 11 That
fiftieth year is to be a jubilee for you. You must not sow, or reap what
grows of itself, or gather the grapes of its untended vines. 12 For it is a
jubilee; it shall be holy for you. You may eat what the field produces.
13 In this year of jubilee each of you is to return to his property. 14 If
you sell anything to your neighbor or buy from your neighbor, you
must not wrong one another. 15 You are to buy from your neighbor
according to the number of years after the jubilee, and he is to sell
to you according to the number of years of crops. 16 If the years are
many, you are to increase the price, and if the years are few, you are
to reduce the price, for it is the number of crops that he is selling to
you. 17 You must not wrong one another, but you are to fear your God,
for I am Yahweh your God.
18 "So you are to do my statutes and keep my judgments and do them,
and you will live in the land securely. 19 The land will yield its fruit,
and you will eat your fill and live in it securely. 20 If you say, 'What will
we eat in the seventh year if we do not sow or gather in our produce?'
21 I will command my blessing for you in the sixth year, so that it will
yield produce for three years. 22 When you sow in the eighth year, you
will eat from the old produce; until the ninth year, when its produce
comes in, you will eat the old.
23 "The land must not be sold permanently,[f] for the land is mine. You
are foreigners and residents with me. 24 Throughout the land of your
possession you are to allow redemption of the land.
25 "If your brother becomes poor and sells some of his property, his
nearest redeemer[g] is to come and redeem what his brother has sold.
26 If a man has no one to redeem it, but he himself prospers and finds
enough to redeem it, 27 he is to count the years since its sale, refund the
balance to the man to whom he sold it, and return to his property. 28
But if he does not find enough to repay him, what he sold will remain

in the hand of the buyer until the year of jubilee. In the jubilee it is to be released, and he will return to his property.
29 "If a man sells a dwelling house in a walled city, its redemption right will last until a full year after its sale; for a full year[h] he may redeem it.
30 If it is not redeemed within a full year, the house in the walled city will belong permanently to the buyer throughout his generations. It will not be released in the jubilee. 31 But houses in villages that have no wall around them are to be counted as part of the fields of the land. They may be redeemed, and they are to be released in the jubilee. 32 As for the cities of the Levites, the houses in the cities they possess, the Levites are to have a permanent right of redemption. 33 And if anyone among the Levites redeems,[i] then the house that was sold in the city of his possession shall go out free in the jubilee; for the houses in the cities of the Levites are their possession among the Israelites. 34 But the field of the common land around their cities may not be sold, for it is their perpetual possession.
35 "If your brother becomes poor and cannot support himself[j] among you, you are to support him; he is to live with you as a foreigner and resident. 36 Do not take interest or profit[k] from him, but fear your God, so that your brother may live with you. 37 You must not lend him your money at interest or give him your food for profit. 38 I am Yahweh your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt to give you the land of Canaan, to be your God.
39 "If your brother near you becomes poor and sells himself to you, you shall not make him work as a slave. 40 He is to be with you as a hired worker or a resident. He is to serve with you until the year of jubilee. 41 Then he and his children with him are to go out from you and return to his own clan, and he is to return to the property of his fathers. 42 For they are my servants, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt; they must not be sold as slaves are sold. 43 You must not rule over him harshly, but you are to fear your God. 44 And as for your male and female slaves, whom you may have: from the nations around you, from them you may buy male and female slaves. 45 You may also buy from the children of the strangers living among you, and from their families living with you who were born in your land;

they may be your property. 46 And you may bequeath them to your sons after you, to inherit as a possession; they shall be your slaves forever. But regarding your brothers, the Israelites, you shall not rule over one another with harshness.

47 "Now if a stranger or sojourner among you becomes rich, and your brother who lives near him becomes poor, and sells himself to the stranger or sojourner among you, or to a member of the stranger's family, 48 after he has sold himself he is to have the right of redemption. One of his brothers may redeem him, 49 or his uncle or his uncle's son may redeem him, or any close relative from his clan may redeem him. Or if he prospers, he may redeem himself. 50 He is to count with his buyer from the year he sold himself to him until the year of jubilee, and the price of his sale is to be in proportion to the number of years. His time with him is to be reckoned as that of a hired worker. 51 If there are still many years left, he is to pay back for his redemption a share of the price for which he was bought, in proportion to them. 52 If only a few years remain until the year of jubilee, he is to count with him and pay back for his redemption in proportion to his years. 53 He is to be with him as a worker hired year by year; he must not rule over him harshly in your sight. 54 If he is not redeemed by these means, he is to go out in the year of jubilee, he and his children with him. 55 For the Israelites are servants to me. They are my servants whom I brought out of the land of Egypt. I am Yahweh your God."

Notes

- a (25:5) Hebrew nazir, literally "your Nazirite," that is, a vine left unpruned, like the uncut hair of a Nazirite (Numbers 6:5).
- b (25:9) Hebrew "in the seventh month, on the tenth of the month," counted from the spring new year of the religious calendar; the month later called Tishri, which, being lunar, fell in September–October. See the notes at 16:29 and 23:24.
- c (25:9) Hebrew shophar teru'ah, "a horn of blasting," the ram's horn.
- d (25:10) Hebrew deror, a legal term for release from debt and servitude. Quoted on the Liberty Bell in Philadelphia; compare Isaiah 61:1; Luke 4:18–19.
- e (25:10) Hebrew yovel, "ram" or "ram's horn," from the horn blown to announce the year. The Latin jubilaeus, from which "jubilee" comes, was influenced by jubilare, "to shout for joy." The Septuagint reads "a year of release."
- f (25:23) Hebrew litsmithuth, "for complete cutting off," that is, beyond the right of redemption.

- g (25:25) Hebrew go'el, the nearest kinsman, responsible to redeem property and persons and to avenge blood (Ruth 3:12–13; Numbers 35:19).
- h (25:29) Literally "days."
- i (25:33) The Hebrew is difficult. The Latin Vulgate reads "If it is not redeemed," which suits the context, and many interpreters supply a negative.
- j (25:35) Literally "his hand falters."
- k (25:36) Hebrew neshekh and tarbith, probably interest taken in advance (literally "bite") and interest added at repayment.

Chapter 26

1 "You must not make idols[a] for yourselves, or set up a carved image or
a sacred pillar for yourselves, and you must not place a carved stone[b]
in your land to bow down to it, for I am Yahweh your God. 2 You are
to keep my Sabbaths and revere my sanctuary. I am Yahweh.[c]
3 "If you walk in my statutes and keep my commandments and do
them, 4 I will give you your rains in their season, the land will yield its
produce, and the trees of the field will yield their fruit. 5 Your thresh-
ing shall continue until the grape harvest, and the grape harvest until
the sowing; you shall eat all the bread you want and live securely in
your land. 6 I will give peace in the land, so that you will lie down
with no one to frighten you; I will remove wild beasts from the land,
and no sword shall pass through your country. 7 You will chase your
enemies, and they will fall before you by the sword. 8 Five of you will
chase a hundred, and a hundred of you will chase ten thousand, and
your enemies will fall before you by the sword. 9 I will turn to you and
make you fruitful and multiply you, and I will confirm my covenant
with you. 10 You will eat old stored grain, and you will clear out the
old to make room for the new. 11 I will set my dwelling[d] among you,
and my soul will not reject you. 12 I will walk among you and will
be your God, and you will be my people.[e] 13 I am Yahweh your God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt, that you should not be
their slaves; I have broken the bands of your yoke and made you go
upright.
14 "But if you do not listen to me and do not do all these command-
ments, 15 if you reject my statutes, and if your soul rejects my
judgments, so that you do not do all my commandments but break

my covenant, 16 then I will do this to you: I will appoint terror over
you, wasting disease and fever that consume the eyes and make the
soul waste away. You will sow your seed in vain, for your enemies
will eat it. 17 I will set my face against you, and you will be struck
down before your enemies. Those who hate you will rule over you,
and you will flee when no one is pursuing you. 18 And after all this,
if you will not obey me, I will punish you seven times more for your
sins. 19 I will break the pride of your power. I will make your sky like
iron and your land like bronze. 20 Your strength will be spent in vain,
for your land will not yield its produce, and the trees of the land will
not yield their fruit.
21 "If you walk contrary[f] to me and are not willing to listen to me, I will
strike you seven times more, according to your sins. 22 I will let loose
among you the wild animals, which will bereave you of your children,
destroy your livestock, and make you few, so that your roads become
deserted.
23 "If by these things you are not corrected toward me, but walk
contrary to me, 24 then I myself will also walk contrary to you, and I
myself will strike you seven times for your sins. 25 I will bring a sword
upon you that will execute the vengeance of the covenant. When you
gather in your cities, I will send pestilence among you, and you will
be given into the hand of the enemy. 26 When I break the staff of bread[g]
for you, ten women shall bake your bread in one oven, and they shall
dole out your bread again by weight; you will eat, but you will not be
satisfied.
27 "If in spite of this you do not listen to me, but walk contrary to me,
28 then I, for my part, will walk against you in furious opposition, and
I myself will punish you sevenfold for your sins. 29 You will eat the
flesh of your sons, and you will eat the flesh of your daughters. 30 I will
destroy your high places and cut down your incense altars[h] and throw
your corpses on the corpses of your idols,[i] and my soul will reject
you. 31 I will make your cities a ruin and lay your sanctuaries waste,
and I will not smell your pleasing aromas. 32 I myself will devastate
the land, and your enemies who live in it will be appalled. 33 You I will

scatter among the nations, and I will unsheathe a sword behind you;
your land shall become a desolation, and your cities a waste.
34 "Then the land will enjoy[j] its Sabbaths all the days that it lies
desolate, while you are in your enemies' land. Then the land will rest
and enjoy its Sabbaths. 35 For as many days as it lies desolate it shall
enjoy the rest it never had on your sabbaths while you lived in it.[k] 36
As for those of you who are left, I will send faintness into their hearts
in the lands of their enemies. The sound of a driven leaf will put them
to flight. They will flee as one flees from the sword, and they will fall
when no one is pursuing. 37 They will stumble over one another as if
before the sword, though no one is pursuing. You will have no power
to stand before your enemies. 38 You will perish among the nations,
and the land of your enemies will devour you. 39 And those of you
who are left shall waste away in the lands of your enemies for their
iniquity; and for the iniquities of their fathers also they shall waste
away with them.
40 "But if they confess their iniquity and the iniquity of their fathers,
in their unfaithfulness that they committed against me, and also that
they walked contrary to me, 41 so that I walked contrary to them and
brought them into the land of their enemies, if then their uncircum-
cised heart is humbled and they make amends for their iniquity,[l] 42
then I will remember my covenant with Jacob, and also my covenant
with Isaac, and also my covenant with Abraham I will remember,[m]
and I will remember the land. 43 For the land will be abandoned by
them and will enjoy its Sabbaths while it lies desolate without them,
while they make amends for their iniquity, because, and only because,
they rejected my judgments and their soul abhorred my statutes. 44 Yet
even so, when they are in the land of their enemies, I will not reject
them, nor will I loathe them so as to wipe them out and break my
covenant with them; for I am Yahweh their God. 45 But for their sake
I will remember the covenant of their ancestors, whom I brought out
of the land of Egypt in the sight of the nations, that I might be their
God: I am Yahweh."

46 These are the statutes, the judgments, and the laws that Yahweh made between himself and the Israelites on Mount Sinai through Moses.

Notes

- a (26:1) Hebrew 'elilim, "worthless things"; see the note at 19:4.
- b (26:1) Hebrew 'even maskith, perhaps a stone carved with figures. The meaning is uncertain.
- c (26:2) Part of the Greek text of this chapter (verses 2–16) survives in a Septuagint scroll from Qumran, 4QLXXLev-a, one of the oldest known manuscripts of the Greek Old Testament. Its readings at several points differ from the standard Septuagint text.
- d (26:11) Hebrew mishkan, "tabernacle." The Septuagint reads "my tabernacle," and some ancient witnesses read "my covenant."
- e (26:12) Quoted in 2 Corinthians 6:16.
- f (26:21) Hebrew qeri, found only in this chapter (verses 21–41), perhaps "in hostility" or "at random" (by chance, as if I did not matter).
- g (26:26) Literally "break your staff of bread."
- h (26:30) Hebrew ḥammanim, perhaps incense altars or sun pillars. The Septuagint reads "wooden images made with hands."
- i (26:30) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous word for idols, perhaps "dung pellets."
- j (26:34) Or "pay off" or "make up for." The Hebrew ratsah is the verb used for the acceptance of sacrifices; it recurs in verses 41 and 43.
- k (26:35) Compare 2 Chronicles 36:21.
- l (26:41) Or "they accept the punishment for their iniquity"; so in verse 43.
- m (26:42) The patriarchs are listed in reverse order, Jacob, Isaac, Abraham. Their names are explained in Genesis: Abraham, "father of a multitude" (17:5); Isaac, "he laughs" (21:6); Jacob, "he grasps the heel" (25:26).

Chapter 27

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and say to them: When anyone makes a special vow[a] to Yahweh, the persons being valued by you, 3 the valuation of a male from twenty to sixty years old is to be about 20 ounces of silver,[b] by the sanctuary standard.[c] 4 If it is a female, the valuation is to be about 12 ounces.[d] 5 If the person is from five to twenty years old, the valuation of a male is to be about 8 ounces, and of a female about 4 ounces.[e] 6 If the person is from a month to five years old, the valuation of a male is to be about 2 ounces of silver, and for a female the valuation is to be about 1.2 ounces of silver.[f] 7 If the person is sixty years old or over, the valuation

of a male is to be about 6 ounces, and of a female about 4 ounces.[g] 8 But if he is too poor to pay the valuation, he is to be presented before the priest, and the priest is to value him. The priest is to value him according to what the one who made the vow can afford.
9 "If it is an animal of the kind that may be presented as an offering to Yahweh, anything that he gives of such to Yahweh is to be holy. 10 He must not exchange it or substitute for it, good for bad or bad for good. If he does substitute one animal for another, then both it and its substitute will be holy. 11 If it is any unclean animal that may not be presented as an offering to Yahweh, he is to present the animal before the priest, 12 and the priest is to value it as either good or bad. As the priest values it, so it will be. 13 If he wishes to redeem it, he is to add a fifth to its valuation.
14 "When a man consecrates his house as holy to Yahweh, the priest is to value it as either good or bad. As the priest values it, so it will stand. 15 If the one who consecrated it wishes to redeem his house, he is to add a fifth to the price of its valuation, and it will be his.
16 "If a man consecrates to Yahweh part of a field of his own property, its valuation is to be in proportion to the seed needed for it: a field sown with about 6 bushels[h] of barley seed is to be valued at about 20 ounces of silver. 17 If he dedicates his field beginning in the year of jubilee, the value you set shall stand. 18 But if he dedicates his field after the jubilee, the priest shall compute the money by the number of years remaining until the year of jubilee, and the amount you set shall be reduced. 19 If the one who consecrated the field wishes to redeem it, he is to add a fifth to the price of its valuation, and it will remain his. 20 But if he does not redeem the field, or if he has sold the field to another man, it may no longer be redeemed. 21 When the field is released in the jubilee, it is to be holy to Yahweh, like a field that has been devoted.[i] It is to be the priest's property. 22 And if a man dedicates to Yahweh a field which he has bought, which is not a part of his own property, 23 then the priest shall reckon to him the worth of your valuation, up to the year of jubilee, and he shall give your valuation on that day as a holy thing to Yahweh. 24 In the year of jubilee the field shall return to him from whom it was bought, to

the one whose possession the land was. 25 Every valuation is to be by
the sanctuary standard.[j]
26 "But the firstborn of the animals, which should be Yahweh's first-
born, no man shall dedicate; whether ox or sheep, it is Yahweh's. 27 If
it is one of the unclean animals, he may buy it back at the value you
set, adding a fifth to it; and if it is not bought back, it shall be sold at
the value you set."
28 "But nothing that a man devotes to Yahweh of all that he has,
whether person, animal, or field of his own property, may be sold or
redeemed. Every devoted thing is most holy to Yahweh. 29 No person
who has been devoted to destruction[k] from among people may be
ransomed; he is surely to be put to death.
30 "Every tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the
fruit of the trees, belongs to Yahweh; it is holy to Yahweh. 31 If a
man wishes to redeem any of his tithe, he is to add a fifth to it. 32
As for every tithe of the herd or flock, every tenth one that passes
under the shepherd's rod[l] is to be holy to Yahweh. 33 He must not
inspect whether it is good or bad, nor make a substitute for it. If he
does substitute for it, then both it and its substitute will be holy; it
may not be redeemed." 34 These are the commandments that Yahweh
commanded Moses for the Israelites on Mount Sinai.

Notes

- a (27:2) Or "an extraordinary vow"; see the note at 22:21. Persons vowed to Yahweh (compare 1 Samuel 1:11) were redeemed by paying their valuation to the sanctuary.
- b (27:3) Hebrew "fifty shekels of silver." The shekel was a unit of weight, about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); fifty shekels were about 20 ounces (575 grams). The Septuagint reads "didrachms" throughout this chapter.
- c (27:3) Literally "by the shekel of the sanctuary," the official standard weight; see verse 25.
- d (27:4) Hebrew "thirty shekels," about 345 grams.
- e (27:5) Hebrew "twenty shekels" (about 230 grams) and "ten shekels" (about 115 grams).
- f (27:6) Hebrew "five shekels" (about 57.5 grams) and "three shekels" (about 34.5 grams).
- g (27:7) Hebrew "fifteen shekels" (about 172.5 grams) and "ten shekels" (about 115 grams).

- h (27:16) Hebrew “a homer,” a dry measure of about 6 bushels (about 220 liters), probably originally a donkey load (Hebrew ḥamor, “donkey”). The value is “fifty shekels of silver,” about 575 grams.
- i (27:21) Hebrew ḥerem, something irrevocably given over to Yahweh, either to the sanctuary or to destruction; see verses 28–29.
- j (27:25) Hebrew “the shekel of the sanctuary; twenty gerahs are to be the shekel.” The gerah was the smallest weight, 1/20 of a shekel, about 0.02 ounce (about 0.6 gram).
- k (27:29) Or “who has been devoted” (Hebrew ḥerem). This refers to persons condemned under the ban, as in Deuteronomy 13:12–18 and Joshua 6:17, not to persons vowed in verses 2–8.
- l (27:32) Literally “passes under the rod,” as a shepherd counts his flock (Jeremiah 33:13; Ezekiel 20:37).

Numbers

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses in the Wilderness of Sinai,[a] in the tent of
meeting, on the first day of the second month (in April–May)[b], in the
second year after they had come out of the land of Egypt, saying, 2
"Take a census[c] of all the congregation of the Israelites, by their clans,
by their fathers' houses, according to the number of names, every
male, head by head. 3 From twenty years old and upward, everyone in
Israel who is able to go out to war, you and Aaron are to count them
by their divisions.[d] 4 With you there is to be a man from each tribe,
each one the head of his father's house.
5 "These are the names of the men who are to stand with you:
from Reuben, Elizur[e] son of Shedeur; 6 from Simeon, Shelumiel son
of Zurishaddai;[f] 7 from Judah, Nahshon son of Amminadab; 8 from
Issachar, Nethanel son of Zuar; 9 from Zebulun, Eliab son of Helon; 10
from the sons of Joseph: from Ephraim, Elishama son of Ammihud;
from Manasseh, Gamaliel son of Pedahzur; 11 from Benjamin, Abidan
son of Gideoni; 12 from Dan, Ahiezer son of Ammishaddai; 13 from
Asher, Pagiel son of Ochran; 14 from Gad, Eliasaph son of Deuel;[g] 15
from Naphtali, Ahira son of Enan." 16 These were the men summoned
from the assembly, chiefs of their ancestral tribes; they were the heads
of the divisions[h] of Israel.
17 Moses and Aaron took these men who had been designated by
name, 18 and on the first day of the second month (in April–May) they
assembled all the congregation. They registered their descent by their
clans, by their fathers' houses, according to the number of names,
from twenty years old and upward, head by head, 19 as Yahweh had
commanded Moses. So he counted them in the Wilderness of Sinai.
20 The sons of Reuben, Israel's firstborn: their descendants, by their
families and their ancestral households, counted by name, head by

head, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 21 those counted of the tribe of Reuben were 46,500.
22 The sons of Simeon: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, head by head, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 23 those counted of the tribe of Simeon were 59,300.
24 The sons of Gad: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 25 those counted of the tribe of Gad were 45,650.
26 The sons of Judah: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 27 those counted of the tribe of Judah were 74,600.
28 The sons of Issachar: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 29 those counted of the tribe of Issachar were 54,400.
30 The sons of Zebulun: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 31 those counted of the tribe of Zebulun were 57,400.
32 The sons of Joseph, namely the sons of Ephraim: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 33 those counted of the tribe of Ephraim were 40,500.
34 The sons of Manasseh: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 35 those counted of the tribe of Manasseh were 32,200.
36 The sons of Benjamin: their descendants, by their families and their ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old and up, all who were fit for war service: 37 those counted of the tribe of Benjamin were 35,400.

38 The sons of Dan: their descendants, by their families and their
ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old
and up, all who were fit for war service: 39 those counted of the tribe
of Dan were 62,700.
40 The sons of Asher: their descendants, by their families and their
ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old
and up, all who were fit for war service: 41 those counted of the tribe
of Asher were 41,500.
42 The sons of Naphtali: their descendants, by their families and their
ancestral households, counted by name, every male twenty years old
and up, all who were fit for war service: 43 those counted of the tribe
of Naphtali were 53,400.
44 These are those who were counted, whom Moses and Aaron
counted with the leaders of Israel, twelve men, each representing
his father's house. 45 So all the Israelites who were counted, by their
ancestral households, twenty years old and up, every man in Israel
fit for war service, 46 all those counted were 603,550.[i]
47 But the Levites were not counted among them by their ancestral
tribe. 48 For Yahweh had spoken to Moses, saying, 49 "Only the tribe
of Levi you are not to count, and you are not to take a census of
them among the Israelites. 50 Instead, appoint the Levites over the
tabernacle of the testimony, over all its furnishings, and over all that
belongs to it. They are to carry the tabernacle and all its furnishings,
they are to minister to it, and they are to camp around the tabernacle.
51 When the tabernacle is to set out, the Levites are to take it down,
and when the tabernacle is to be pitched, the Levites are to set it up.
Any outsider[j] who comes near is to be put to death. 52 The Israelites
are to camp each in his own camp and each by his own banner, by
their divisions. 53 But the Levites shall encamp around the tabernacle
of the testimony, so that no wrath may fall on the congregation
of the Israelites; the Levites shall have charge of the tabernacle of
the testimony." 54 The Israelites did so; according to all that Yahweh
commanded Moses, so they did.

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew midbar, “wilderness,” open grazing land or steppe as well as desert. The book’s Hebrew title is Bemidbar, “In the Wilderness,” from this verse. The English title “Numbers” comes from the Septuagint (Arithmoi) and the Vulgate (Numeri), after the two censuses of chapters 1 and 26.
- b (1:1) Hebrew “on the first of the second month,” counting from the spring new year (Exodus 12:2). The second month, later called Iyyar (Ziv in 1 Kings 6:1), fell in April–May. Because the months were lunar, each overlaps two of ours. This was one month after the tabernacle was set up (Exodus 40:17).
- c (1:2) Hebrew “lift up the head,” an idiom for counting.
- d (1:3) Or “by their armies.” Hebrew tsava’, used of organized hosts, especially for war.
- e (1:5) Many of the names in this list contain the name of God: El (“God”), Shaddai (see the note at Exodus 6:3), or Tsur (“Rock”). Elizur means “my God is a rock.”
- f (1:6) Shelumiel means “God is my peace”; Zurishaddai means “Shaddai is my rock.”
- g (1:14) Most Hebrew manuscripts read “Deuel” here and in 7:42, 47; 10:20, but “Reuel” in 2:14. The letters d and r look very similar in Hebrew script. The Septuagint reads Ragouel throughout.
- h (1:16) Or “clans,” “units.” See the note at verse 46.
- i (1:46) The census figures in this chapter and in chapter 26 add up exactly, and they are given here as the Hebrew has them. A total of 603,550 fighting men would imply a population of perhaps two million or more. Because the Hebrew word elef, normally “thousand,” can also mean a clan or a military unit (see verse 16; Judges 6:15; 1 Samuel 10:19), some scholars have proposed that the figures originally counted units and men (for example, “46 units, 500 men”). Others hold that the numbers are meant literally, or that they are deliberately large, symbolic figures. The same total appears in Exodus 38:26, and a similar one in Exodus 12:37. This translation keeps the numbers as written.
- j (1:51) Hebrew zar, someone who is not a Levite.

Chapter 2

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 2 “The Israelites are
to camp each by his own banner, with the emblems[a] of their fathers’
houses. They are to camp facing the tent of meeting on every side, at
a distance.
3 “On the east side, toward the sunrise, those who camp are to be of
the banner of the camp of Judah, by their divisions. The leader of
the descendants of Judah is Nahshon son of Amminadab, 4 and his
division, as counted, is 74,600. 5 Those who camp next to him are to
be the tribe of Issachar. The leader of the descendants of Issachar is

Nethanel son of Zuar, [6] and his division, as counted, is 54,400. [7] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Zebulun. The leader of the descendants of Zebulun is Eliab son of Helon, [8] and his division, as counted, is 57,400. [9] All those counted of the camp of Judah are 186,400, by their divisions. They are to set out first.

[10] "On the south side, those who camp are to be of the banner of the camp of Reuben, by their divisions. The leader of the descendants of Reuben is Elizur son of Shedeur, [11] and his division, as counted, is 46,500. [12] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Simeon. The leader of the descendants of Simeon is Shelumiel son of Zurishaddai, [13] and his division, as counted, is 59,300. [14] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Gad. The leader of the descendants of Gad is Eliasaph son of Reuel[b], [15] and his division, as counted, is 45,650. [16] All those counted of the camp of Reuben are 151,450, by their divisions. They are to set out second.

[17] "Then the tent of meeting is to set out, with the camp of the Levites in the middle of the camps. As they camp, so they are to set out, each in his place, by their banners.

[18] "On the west side, those who camp are to be of the banner of the camp of Ephraim, by their divisions. The leader of the descendants of Ephraim is Elishama son of Ammihud, [19] and his division, as counted, is 40,500. [20] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Manasseh. The leader of the descendants of Manasseh is Gamaliel son of Pedahzur, [21] and his division, as counted, is 32,200. [22] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Benjamin. The leader of the descendants of Benjamin is Abidan son of Gideoni, [23] and his division, as counted, is 35,400. [24] The total of those counted for the camp of Ephraim was 108,100, by their divisions; they shall set out third.

[25] "On the north side, those who camp are to be of the banner of the camp of Dan, by their divisions. The leader of the descendants of Dan is Ahiezer son of Ammishaddai, [26] and his division, as counted, is 62,700. [27] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Asher. The leader of the descendants of Asher is Pagiel son of Ochran, [28] and his division, as counted, is 41,500. [29] Those who camp next to him are to be the tribe of Naphtali. The leader of the descendants of Naphtali is

Ahira son of Enan, 30 and his division, as counted, is 53,400. 31 All those
counted of the camp of Dan are 157,600, by their divisions. They are
to set out last, by their banners."
32 These are those of the Israelites who were counted by their fathers'
houses. All those counted in the camps by their divisions were
603,550. 33 But the Levites were not counted among the Israelites, as
Yahweh had commanded Moses. 34 The Israelites did according to all
that Yahweh commanded Moses. So they camped by their banners,
and so they set out, each by his clan, according to his father's house.

Notes

- a (2:2) Or "signs," perhaps flags or standards. Hebrew degel ("banner") marks each group of three tribes, and ot ("sign") each father's house.
- b (2:14) Hebrew Reuel. Elsewhere in Numbers most manuscripts read Deuel; see the note at 1:14.

Chapter 3

1 This is the family history of Aaron and Moses from the time Yahweh
spoke with Moses on Mount Sinai. 2 These are the names of the
sons of Aaron: Nadab the firstborn, and Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar.
3 These are the names of the sons of Aaron, the anointed priests,
whom he ordained[a] to serve as priests. 4 But Nadab and Abihu died
in Yahweh's presence when they offered strange fire before Yahweh
in the Wilderness of Sinai; and they had no children.[b] So Eleazar
and Ithamar ministered as priests during the lifetime of their father
Aaron.
5 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 6 "Bring the tribe of Levi near and set
them before Aaron the priest, so that they may minister to him. 7 They
are to keep his duties and the duties of the whole congregation before
the tent of meeting, as they do the service of the tabernacle. 8 They
are to take care of all the furnishings of the tent of meeting and keep
the duties of the Israelites, as they do the service of the tabernacle.
9 You are to give the Levites to Aaron and his sons; they are given
wholly to him[c] from among the Israelites. 10 You are to appoint Aaron
and his sons, and they are to keep their priesthood. Any outsider who
comes near is to be put to death."

11 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 12 "I myself have taken the Levites
from among the Israelites to stand in place of every firstborn that first
opens the womb among the Israelites; the Levites shall be mine, 13 for
every firstborn is mine. On the day that I struck down every firstborn
in the land of Egypt, I consecrated for myself every firstborn in Israel,
both human and animal. They are to be mine. I am Yahweh."
14 Yahweh spoke to Moses in the Wilderness of Sinai, saying, 15 "Count
the descendants of Levi by their fathers' houses, by their clans. You
are to count every male from a month old and upward." 16 So Moses
counted them at the word[d] of Yahweh, as he was commanded. 17
These were the sons of Levi by their names: Gershon, Kohath, and
Merari. 18 These are the names of the sons of Gershon by their clans:
Libni and Shimei. 19 The sons of Kohath by their clans: Amram, Izhar,
Hebron, and Uzziel. 20 And the sons of Merari, by their families: Mahli
and Mushi. These were the families of the Levites, by their ancestral
houses.
21 Of Gershon were the Libnite family and the Shimeite family;
these were the Gershonite families. 22 Those counted of them, by the
number of all the males from a month old and upward, were 7,500. 23
The clans of the Gershonites were to camp behind the tabernacle, on
the west. 24 The leader of the father's house of the Gershonites was
Eliasaph son of Lael. 25 The responsibility of the sons of Gershon in the
tent of meeting concerned the tabernacle, the tent with its covering,
and the curtain at the entrance of the tent of meeting, 26 the hangings
of the court, the curtain for the court's entrance, which surrounds the
tabernacle and the altar, and its cords—everything needed for their
service.
27 Of Kohath were the Amramite family, the Izharite family, the
Hebronite family, and the Uzzielite family; these were the Kohathite
families. 28 By the number of all the males from a month old and
upward, there were 8,600,[e] keeping the duties of the sanctuary. 29 The
clans of the descendants of Kohath were to camp on the south side
of the tabernacle. 30 The leader of the father's house of the clans of
the Kohathites was Elizaphan son of Uzziel. 31 Their duty was the ark,
the table, the lampstand, the altars, the utensils of the sanctuary with

which they minister, and the screen, with all the service connected with them. 32 The chief of the leaders of the Levites was Eleazar son of Aaron the priest, with oversight of those who kept the duties of the sanctuary.
33 Of Merari were the Mahlite family and the Mushite family; these were the families of Merari. 34 Those counted of them, by the number of all the males from a month old and upward, were 6,200. 35 The chief of the ancestral house of the Merarite families was Zuriel, son of Abihail; their camp was to be pitched on the tabernacle's northern side. 36 The appointed duty of the descendants of Merari was the frames of the tabernacle, its crossbars, its posts, its bases, and all its equipment, with all the service connected with them, 37 and the posts of the courtyard all around, with their bases, their tent pegs, and their cords.
38 Camping before the tabernacle on the east side, in front of the tent of meeting toward the sunrise, were Moses, Aaron, and his sons, who kept charge of the sanctuary on behalf of the Israelites; and any unauthorized person who approached was to be put to death. 39 All those counted of the Levites, whom Moses and Aaron[f] counted at the word of Yahweh by their clans, all the males from a month old and upward, were 22,000.[g]
40 Yahweh said to Moses, "Count all the firstborn males of the Israelites from a month old and upward, and take the number of their names. 41 You are to take the Levites for me, I am Yahweh, in place of all the firstborn among the Israelites, and the livestock of the Levites in place of all the firstborn among the livestock of the Israelites." 42 So Moses counted, as Yahweh commanded him, all the firstborn among the Israelites. 43 All the firstborn males, by the number of names, from a month old and upward, as counted, were 22,273.
44 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 45 "Take the Levites in the place of all the Israelites' firstborn, and the Levites' livestock in place of their livestock; and the Levites shall be mine: I am Yahweh. 46 As the redemption price for the 273 firstborn of the Israelites who outnumber the Levites, 47 you are to take about 2 ounces of silver[h] for each one, head by head; you are to take it by the sanctuary standard. 48

and give the money to Aaron and his sons, as the ransom for the surplus among them." [49] So Moses took the ransom money from those who were over and above the ones redeemed by the Levites. [50] From the firstborn of the Israelites he took the money, about 34 pounds of silver,[i] by the sanctuary standard. [51] Moses gave the redemption money to Aaron and his sons, at the word of Yahweh, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

Notes

- a (3:3) Hebrew "whose hand he filled," the expression for installing priests (Exodus 28:41).
- b (3:4) See Leviticus 10:1–2.
- c (3:9) Hebrew "given, given," stressing that they are wholly given. The Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "given to me"; compare 8:16.
- d (3:16) Hebrew "mouth."
- e (3:28) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint. Some scholars propose "8,300," which would make the three Levite clans add up to the total of 22,000 in verse 39 (7,500 + 8,300 + 6,200). In Hebrew, "six" (shesh) and "three" (shalosh) differ by a single letter.
- f (3:39) In the Hebrew text the words "and Aaron" are marked with extraordinary dots above the letters, a sign that ancient scribes doubted whether they belonged. Some ancient witnesses lack them.
- g (3:39) The clan figures in verses 22, 28, and 34 add up to 22,300. See the note at verse 28.
- h (3:47) Hebrew "five shekels," about 57 grams. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); standards varied. The text adds, "the shekel is twenty gerahs"; a gerah was one-twentieth of a shekel. On the "sanctuary shekel," see Exodus 30:13.
- i (3:50) Hebrew "1,365 shekels," about 15.7 kilograms.

Chapter 4

[1] Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, [2] "Take a head count of the sons of Kohath from among the sons of Levi, by their families and their ancestral houses, [3] from thirty years old up to fifty years old, all who come into the service[a] to do work in the tent of meeting. [4] This is the service of the descendants of Kohath in the tent of meeting: the most holy things.

[5] "When the camp is about to move, Aaron and his sons shall enter, take down the screening curtain, and cover the ark of the testimony with it; [6] then they shall put a covering of fine leather[b] over it, spread

a cloth entirely of blue on top, and insert its poles. 7 Upon the table of
the Presence they shall lay a blue cloth, and put on it the dishes, the
spoons, the bowls, and the jars for pouring libations; the continual
bread shall remain upon it. 8 They are to spread over them a cloth
of scarlet and cover it with a covering of fine leather, and put in its
poles. 9 They shall take a blue cloth and cover the lampstand that gives
light, together with its lamps, its tongs, its trays, and all its oil vessels
with which they supply it. 10 They shall wrap it with all its utensils
in a covering of fine leather, and put it on a carrying frame. 11 Over
the golden altar they are to spread a cloth of blue and cover it with
a covering of fine leather, and put in its poles. 12 They are to take all
the utensils of service with which they minister in the sanctuary, put
them in a cloth of blue, cover them with a covering of fine leather, and
put them on the carrying frame. 13 They are to remove the ashes from
the altar and spread a purple cloth over it. 14 And they shall place upon
it all the utensils used for its service: the firepans, the fleshhooks, the
shovels, and the basins—all the utensils of the altar; and they shall
spread on it a covering of fine leather and insert its poles.[c] 15 When
Aaron and his sons have finished covering the sanctuary and all its
furnishings as the camp prepares to move, the sons of Kohath shall
then come to carry them; yet they must never touch the holy things,
or they will die. This is what the sons of Kohath are to carry from the
tent of meeting.
16 "Eleazar son of Aaron the priest is to have oversight of the oil for
the light, the fragrant incense, the regular grain offering, and the
anointing oil, the oversight of the whole tabernacle and all that is in
it, the sanctuary and its furnishings."
17 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 18 "Do not let the tribe
of the clans of the Kohathites be cut off from among the Levites. 19 But
do this for them, that they may live and not die when they approach
the most holy things: Aaron and his sons shall go in and assign each
man to his task and his burden. 20 But they shall not go in to see the
holy things, even for a moment,[d] lest they die."
21 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 22 "Take a census of the descendants
of Gershon also, by their fathers' houses, by their clans. 23 From thirty

years old and upward to fifty years old you are to count them, all who enter to perform the service, to do the work in the tent of meeting.
24 This is the service of the Gershonite families, in serving and in carrying: 25 they are to carry the curtains of the tabernacle and the tent of meeting, its covering, the covering of fine leather that is on top of it, the screen for the entrance of the tent of meeting, 26 the hangings of the court, the curtain for the entrance of the gateway of the court that surrounds the tabernacle and the altar, their cords, and all the instruments of their service; and they shall do everything that is to be done with these. 27 All the service of the descendants of the Gershonites, in all their carrying and in all their service, is to be at the command[e] of Aaron and his sons. You are to assign to them as their duty all that they are to carry. 28 This is the service of the Gershonite families in the tent of meeting; and their charge shall be under the supervision[f] of Ithamar the son of Aaron the priest.
29 "As for the descendants of Merari, you are to count them by their clans, by their fathers' houses. 30 From thirty years old and upward to fifty years old you are to count them, everyone who enters the service, to do the work of the tent of meeting. 31 This is what they are charged to carry, as all their service in the tent of meeting: the frames of the tabernacle, its crossbars, its posts, and its bases, 32 and the posts of the courtyard all around with their bases, tent pegs, and cords, with all their equipment and all their service. You are to assign by name the items that they are charged to carry. 33 This is the service of the clans of the descendants of Merari, all their service in the tent of meeting, under the direction of Ithamar son of Aaron the priest."
34 Moses and Aaron and the leaders of the congregation counted the descendants of the Kohathites by their clans and by their fathers' houses, 35 from thirty years old up to fifty years old, all who came into the service to work in the tent of meeting, 36 Those counted of them by their clans were 2,750. 37 These were those counted of the clans of the Kohathites, all who served in the tent of meeting, whom Moses and Aaron counted at the word of Yahweh through Moses.
38 Those counted of the descendants of Gershon, by their clans and by their fathers' houses, 39 from thirty years old up to fifty years

old, all who came into the service to work in the tent of meeting, [40] those counted of them by their clans, by their fathers' houses, were 2,630. [41] These were those counted of the clans of the descendants of Gershon, all who served in the tent of meeting, whom Moses and Aaron counted at the word of Yahweh.
[42] Those counted of the clans of the descendants of Merari, by their clans, by their fathers' houses, [43] from thirty years old up to fifty years old, all who came into the service to work in the tent of meeting, [44] those counted of them by their clans were 3,200. [45] These were those counted of the clans of the descendants of Merari, whom Moses and Aaron counted at the word of Yahweh through Moses.
[46] All those counted of the Levites, whom Moses and Aaron and the leaders of Israel counted, by their clans and by their fathers' houses, [47] from thirty years old up to fifty years old, all who came to do the work of serving and the work of carrying in the tent of meeting, [48] those counted of them were 8,580. [49] At the word of Yahweh through Moses they were appointed, each to his service and to his load. So they were counted by him, as Yahweh commanded Moses.

Notes

- a (4:3) Hebrew tsava', "host," here the organized service of the Levites. In 8:24 the starting age is twenty-five; compare 1 Chronicles 23:24–27, where it is twenty.
- b (4:6) Hebrew tahash; see the note at Exodus 25:5. So also in verses 8–14 and 25.
- c (4:14) The Samaritan Pentateuch and the Septuagint add, "They are to take a purple cloth and cover the basin and its stand, put it in a covering of fine leather, and put it on the carrying frame." This is one of the longer readings that the Samaritan Pentateuch shares with other witnesses in Numbers; see the note at 10:10.
- d (4:20) Hebrew "as a swallowing," perhaps "even for the time it takes to swallow."
- e (4:27) Hebrew "mouth."
- f (4:28) Hebrew "hand." So also in verse 33.

Chapter 5

[1] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [2] "Command the Israelites to put out of the camp everyone with a defiling skin disease,[a] everyone with a discharge, and everyone made unclean by a corpse. [3] You are to send out both male and female; you are to send them outside the camp, so that they do not defile their camps, in the midst of which I dwell." [4]

The Israelites did so and sent them outside the camp. As Yahweh had spoken to Moses, so the Israelites did.
5 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 6 "Say to the Israelites: When a man or woman commits any wrong against another, breaking faith with Yahweh, and that person is found guilty, 7 he is to confess the sin that he has committed. He is to make restitution for his guilt in full, add a fifth to it, and give it to the one he has wronged. 8 But if the man has no kinsman[b] to whom the compensation can be paid, the compensation for the wrong goes to Yahweh, to be the priest's, apart from the atonement ram with which atonement is made for him. 9 Every contribution of all the holy things of the Israelites, which they bring to the priest, is to be his. 10 Each person's holy things are his own; whatever anyone gives to the priest is to be the priest's."
11 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 12 "Speak to the Israelites and tell them: If any man's wife turns aside and is unfaithful to him, 13 and a man has intercourse with her, and it is concealed from her husband's eyes and kept secret, though she has defiled herself, and there is no witness against her and she was not caught in the act, 14 and a spirit of jealousy comes upon him, and he suspects his wife who has defiled herself; or a spirit of jealousy comes upon him, and he suspects his wife, though she has not defiled herself, 15 then the man is to bring his wife to the priest. He is to bring the offering required for her, about 2 quarts of barley flour.[c] He is not to pour oil on it or put frankincense on it, for it is a grain offering of jealousy, a grain offering of remembrance, bringing iniquity to remembrance.
16 "The priest is to bring her near and set her before Yahweh. 17 The priest is to take holy water in an earthen vessel, and the priest is to take some of the dust that is on the floor of the tabernacle and put it into the water. 18 The priest shall stand the woman before Yahweh and uncover her head, and place in her hands the grain offering of remembrance, the grain offering of jealousy; and in his own hand the priest shall hold the bitter water that brings the curse. 19 And the priest shall put her under oath and say to her, 'If no man has lain with you, and you have not strayed into uncleanness while in your husband's house, be unharmed by this bitter water that brings the curse. 20 But

if you have gone astray while under your husband's authority, and if you have defiled yourself and some man other than your husband has lain with you,' 21 then the priest is to make the woman take the oath of the curse, and the priest is to say to the woman, 'May Yahweh make you a curse and an oath among your people, when Yahweh makes your thigh fall away and your belly swell.[d] 22 May this water that brings the curse go into your body and make your belly swell and your thigh fall away.' And the woman is to say, 'Amen, Amen.'[e]
23 "Then the priest is to write these curses in a scroll and wash them off into the water of bitterness. 24 And he shall make the woman drink the bitter water that brings the curse, and the water that brings the curse shall go into her and become bitter. 25 Then the priest shall take the grain offering of jealousy out of the woman's hand, wave it before Yahweh, and present it at the altar. 26 And the priest shall take a handful of the grain offering as its memorial portion, burn it upon the altar, and afterward make the woman drink the water. 27 When he has made her drink the water, then if she is defiled and has been unfaithful to her husband, the water that brings the curse shall go into her and become bitter, and her belly shall swell and her thigh shall waste away; and the woman shall become a curse among her people. 28 But if the woman has not defiled herself and is pure, she shall be acquitted and shall bear children.
29 "This is the law of jealousy, when a wife, while under her husband's authority, goes astray and defiles herself, 30 or when a spirit of jealousy comes over a man and he is jealous of his wife. He is to set the woman before Yahweh, and the priest is to carry out for her all this law. 31 The man will be free from iniquity, but the woman will bear her iniquity."

Notes

- a (5:2) Hebrew tsara'at, a term for various skin diseases (Leviticus 13–14), traditionally translated "leprosy," though it is not limited to what is now called leprosy (Hansen's disease).
- b (5:8) Hebrew go'el, the nearest relative, who had the right and duty to receive or pay redemption for a family member.
- c (5:15) Hebrew "a tenth of an ephah of barley flour," about 2.2 liters. An ephah was about three-fifths of a bushel (22 liters); standards varied.

- d (5:21) The exact meaning of "thigh" (perhaps a euphemism for the reproductive organs) and of the physical effects is uncertain. They may describe a miscarriage or infertility (compare verse 28).
- e (5:22) Hebrew amen, "so be it," a word of solemn agreement.

Chapter 6

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and say
to them: When a man or a woman makes a special vow, the vow of
a Nazirite,[a] to separate himself to Yahweh, 3 he is to separate himself
from wine and strong drink. He must not drink vinegar made from
wine or vinegar made from strong drink, and he must not drink any
grape juice or eat grapes, fresh or dried. 4 All the days of his separation
he must not eat anything produced by the grapevine, from the seeds
to the skins.[b]
5 "All the days of his vow of separation no razor is to pass over his
head. Until the days are fulfilled for which he separates himself to
Yahweh, he is to be holy. He is to let the locks of the hair of his head
grow long.
6 "All the days that he separates himself to Yahweh he must not go
near a dead person. 7 Not even for his father or for his mother, for his
brother or for his sister, if they die, is he to make himself unclean,
because his separation to God is on his head. 8 All the days of his
separation he is holy to Yahweh.
9 "If anyone dies very suddenly beside him and he defiles his conse-
crated head, he is to shave his head on the day of his cleansing; on the
seventh day he is to shave it. 10 On the eighth day he shall bring two
turtledoves or two young pigeons to the priest at the door of the tent
of meeting. 11 The priest is to offer one as a sin offering and the other
as a burnt offering and make atonement for him, because he sinned
by reason of the dead body. He is to consecrate his head that same
day. 12 He shall dedicate to Yahweh his days of separation anew, and
bring a male lamb in its first year for a guilt offering; but the former
days are void,[c] because his separation was defiled.
13 "This is the law of the Nazirite when the days of his separation are
fulfilled. He is to be brought to the entrance of the tent of meeting,
14 and he shall present his offering to Yahweh: a male lamb in its first

year, without blemish, for a burnt offering; a ewe lamb in its first year, without blemish, for a sin offering; and one ram without blemish for a peace offering; 15 a basket of unleavened bread, cakes of fine flour mingled with oil, and unleavened wafers anointed with oil, along with their grain offering and their drink offerings. 16 The priest is to present them before Yahweh and offer his sin offering and his burnt offering. 17 He is to offer the ram as a sacrifice of peace offering to Yahweh, with the basket of unleavened bread. The priest is also to offer its grain offering and its drink offering. 18 There at the entrance of the tent of meeting the Nazirite shall shave his consecrated head, and shall take the hair from it and lay it on the fire under the sacrifice of the peace offering. 19 The priest is to take the boiled shoulder of the ram, one unleavened cake out of the basket, and one unleavened wafer, and put them on the palms of the Nazirite after he has shaved his consecrated head. 20 The priest is to wave them as a wave offering before Yahweh. They are a holy portion for the priest, together with the breast that is waved and the thigh that is contributed. After that the Nazirite may drink wine.

21 "This is the law of the Nazirite who vows his offering to Yahweh for his separation, in addition to whatever else he can afford. In keeping with the vow that he makes, so he must do according to the law of his separation."

22 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 23 "Speak to Aaron and his sons, saying, 'This is how you are to bless the Israelites. Say to them:[d] 24 "May Yahweh bless you and keep you; 25 may Yahweh make his face shine on you and be gracious to you; 26 may Yahweh lift up his face toward you and give you peace."'[e] 27 So they are to put my name on the Israelites, and I will bless them."

Notes

- a (6:2) Hebrew nazir, from nazar, "to separate" or "to dedicate." Compare Samson (Judges 13:5), Samuel (1 Samuel 1:11), and Acts 18:18; 21:23–26.
- b (6:4) The meaning of the two Hebrew words hartsannim and zag is uncertain; they may refer to unripe grapes and grape skins, or to seeds and skins.
- c (6:12) Hebrew "will fall."
- d (6:23) The blessing in verses 24–26 is three lines of growing length, each naming Yahweh. A form of it is inscribed on two small silver scrolls found at Ketef Hinnom

in Jerusalem, dated to around 600 BC, among the oldest known texts of any biblical passage.

- e (6:26) Hebrew shalom, wholeness and well-being, not merely the absence of conflict.

Chapter 7

1 Now on the day that Moses completed setting up the tabernacle,
he anointed it and sanctified it with all its furnishings, and likewise
anointed and sanctified the altar with all its utensils. 2 the leaders
of Israel, the heads of their fathers' houses, presented offerings.
They were the leaders of the tribes, who were over those who were
counted. 3 And they brought their offering before Yahweh: six covered
carts[a] and twelve oxen—a cart for every two leaders, and for each one
an ox—and presented them before the tabernacle.
4 Then Yahweh said to Moses, 5 "Take these from them, that they may
be used for the work of the tent of meeting; and give them to the
Levites, to every man as his service requires." 6 So Moses took the
wagons and the oxen and gave them to the Levites. 7 He gave two
wagons and four oxen to the descendants of Gershon, according to
their service. 8 He gave four wagons and eight oxen to the descendants
of Merari, according to their service, under the direction of Ithamar
son of Aaron the priest. 9 But to the descendants of Kohath he gave
none, because their service was with the holy things, which they had
to carry on their shoulders.
10 The leaders presented offerings for the dedication[b] of the altar on
the day it was anointed; the leaders presented their offering in front of
the altar. 11 Yahweh said to Moses, "They are to present their offering,
one leader each day, for the dedication of the altar."
12 The one who presented his offering on the first day was Nahshon
son of Amminadab, of the tribe of Judah. 13 His offering was one silver
plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾
pounds,[c] by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour
mixed with oil for a grain offering; 14 one gold dish of about 4 ounces,[d]
full of incense; 15 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year
old, for a burnt offering; 16 one male goat for a sin offering; 17 and for
the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats,

and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Nahshon son of Amminadab.
18 On the second day Nethanel son of Zuar, the leader of the descendants of Issachar, presented an offering. 19 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 20 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 21 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 22 one male goat for a sin offering; 23 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Nethanel son of Zuar.
24 On the third day Eliab son of Helon, the leader of the descendants of Zebulun, presented an offering. 25 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 26 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 27 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 28 one male goat for a sin offering; 29 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Eliab son of Helon.
30 On the fourth day Elizur son of Shedeur, the leader of the descendants of Reuben, presented an offering. 31 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 32 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 33 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 34 one male goat for a sin offering; 35 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Elizur son of Shedeur.
36 On the fifth day Shelumiel son of Zurishaddai, the leader of the descendants of Simeon, presented an offering. 37 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour

mixed with oil for a grain offering; [38] one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; [39] one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; [40] one male goat for a sin offering; [41] and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Shelumiel son of Zurishaddai.

[42] On the sixth day Eliasaph son of Deuel, the leader of the descendants of Gad, presented an offering. [43] His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; [44] one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; [45] one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; [46] one male goat for a sin offering; [47] and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Eliasaph son of Deuel.

[48] On the seventh day Elishama son of Ammihud, the leader of the descendants of Ephraim, presented an offering. [49] His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; [50] one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; [51] one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; [52] one male goat for a sin offering; [53] and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Elishama son of Ammihud.

[54] On the eighth day Gamaliel son of Pedahzur, the leader of the descendants of Manasseh, presented an offering. [55] His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; [56] one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; [57] one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; [58] one male goat for a sin offering; [59] and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Gamaliel son of Pedahzur.

60 On the ninth day Abidan son of Gideoni, the leader of the descendants of Benjamin, presented an offering. 61 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 62 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 63 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 64 one male goat for a sin offering; 65 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Abidan son of Gideoni.
66 On the tenth day Ahiezer son of Ammishaddai, the leader of the descendants of Dan, presented an offering. 67 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 68 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 69 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 70 one male goat for a sin offering; 71 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Ahiezer son of Ammishaddai.
72 On the eleventh day Pagiel the son of Ochran, leader of the sons of Asher, made his offering. 73 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 74 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 75 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old, for a burnt offering; 76 one male goat for a sin offering; 77 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Pagiel son of Ochran.
78 On the twelfth day Ahira son of Enan, the leader of the descendants of Naphtali, presented an offering. 79 His offering was one silver plate weighing about 3¼ pounds and one silver bowl of about 1¾ pounds, by the sanctuary standard, both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil for a grain offering; 80 one gold dish of about 4 ounces, full of incense; 81 one young bull, one ram, and one male lamb a year old,

for a burnt offering; 82 one male goat for a sin offering; 83 and for the sacrifice of peace offerings, two oxen, five rams, five male goats, and five male lambs a year old. This was the offering of Ahira son of Enan.
84 This was the altar's dedication gift from the leaders of Israel, given when it was anointed: twelve silver plates, twelve silver bowls, twelve gold pans; 85 Each silver plate weighed about 3¼ pounds and each bowl about 1¾ pounds, and all the silver of the vessels came to about 60 pounds,[e] by the sanctuary standard. 86 The twelve gold dishes full of incense weighed about 4 ounces each, by the sanctuary standard, and all the gold of the dishes came to about 3 pounds.[f] 87 All the animals for the burnt offering: twelve bulls, twelve rams, twelve yearling male lambs, with their grain offering; and twelve male goats for a sin offering. 88 All the livestock for the sacrifice of peace offerings were twenty-four bulls, sixty rams, sixty male goats, and sixty male lambs a year old. This was the dedication offering for the altar after it was anointed.
89 When Moses went into the tent of meeting to speak with him,[g] he heard the voice speaking to him from above the atonement cover that was on the ark of the testimony, from between the two cherubim; and he spoke to him.

Notes

- a (7:3) Hebrew tsav, perhaps "covered" or "litter-like." The meaning is uncertain.
- b (7:10) Hebrew hanukkah, "dedication," the word later used for the festival of the rededication of the temple in 164 BC. So also in verses 11, 84, and 88.
- c (7:13) Hebrew "one silver plate, its weight a hundred thirty shekels, one silver bowl of seventy shekels," about 1.5 kilograms and 0.8 kilogram. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); standards varied. On the sanctuary shekel, see Exodus 30:13. The same weights apply in each of the twelve offerings that follow.
- d (7:14) Hebrew "ten shekels," about 115 grams.
- e (7:85) Hebrew "2,400 shekels," about 27.6 kilograms.
- f (7:86) Hebrew "ten shekels each … 120 shekels," about 115 grams each and 1.4 kilograms in all.
- g (7:89) That is, with Yahweh. The Hebrew form translated "speaking" (middabber) is unusual; some interpreters take it to mean that the voice was speaking, as it were, to itself, with Moses overhearing.

Chapter 8

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 “Speak to Aaron and tell him,
‘When you arrange the lamps, the seven lamps shall cast their light
in front of the lampstand.’” 3 And Aaron did so; he arranged the lamps
to face the front of the lampstand, just as Yahweh had commanded
Moses. 4 This was how the lampstand was made: hammered work of
gold. From its base to its flowers it was hammered work. According to
the pattern that Yahweh had shown Moses, so he made the lampstand.
5 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 6 “Take the Levites from among
the Israelites and cleanse them. 7 And thus you shall do to them to
cleanse them: sprinkle water of purification[a] upon them, and have
them shave all their body with a razor, wash their clothes, and so
make themselves clean. 8 Then let them take a young bull with its
grain offering of fine flour mixed with oil, and you are to take another
young bull for a sin offering. 9 You are to bring the Levites in front
of the tent of meeting and assemble the whole congregation of the
Israelites. 10 When you bring the Levites before Yahweh, the Israelites
are to lay their hands on the Levites, 11 Aaron shall offer the Levites
before Yahweh as a wave offering[b] on behalf of the Israelites, that
they may perform the service of Yahweh. 12 Then the Levites are to
lay their hands on the heads of the bulls, and you are to offer one as
a sin offering and the other as a burnt offering to Yahweh, to make
atonement for the Levites. 13 You are to have the Levites stand before
Aaron and his sons and present them as a wave offering to Yahweh.
14 So you shall set the Levites apart from the rest of the Israelites, and
the Levites shall belong to me. 15 After that the Levites may come in
to minister at the tent of meeting, once you have purified them and
offered them up as a wave offering. 16 For they are wholly given to
me from among the Israelites. I have taken them for myself in place
of all who open the womb, the firstborn of all the Israelites. 17 For all
the firstborn among the Israelites are mine, both man and beast; on
the day I struck all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, I set them apart
for myself. 18 And I have taken the Levites in place of all the firstborn
among the Israelites. 19 I have given the Levites as a gift to Aaron and
his sons from among the Israelites, to do the service of the Israelites

at the tent of meeting and to make atonement for the Israelites, so that no plague may come on the Israelites when the Israelites come near the sanctuary."
20 Thus Moses and Aaron and all the congregation of the Israelites did with the Levites; just as Yahweh had commanded Moses concerning them, so the Israelites did to them. 21 The Levites purified themselves from sin and washed their clothes, and Aaron presented them as a wave offering before Yahweh, and Aaron made atonement for them to cleanse them. 22 After that the Levites went in to do their service at the tent of meeting before Aaron and before his sons. As Yahweh had commanded Moses concerning the Levites, so they did to them.
23 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 24 "This is what applies to the Levites: from twenty-five years old and upward they are to come to serve in the work of the tent of meeting.[c] 25 From the age of fifty years they are to retire from the work of the service and serve no more. 26 They may assist their brothers in the tent of meeting by standing guard, but they shall do no service. Thus you shall arrange the duties of the Levites."

Notes

- a (8:7) Hebrew "water of sin," that is, water that removes sin and impurity.
- b (8:11) Hebrew tenufah, an offering formally presented before Yahweh, possibly with a lifting or waving motion.
- c (8:24) Compare 4:3, where the age is thirty. The difference may reflect a period of apprenticeship or a change in practice. The Septuagint has twenty-five in both places (4:3, 23, 30).

Chapter 9

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses in the Wilderness of Sinai, in the first month of the second year after they had come out of the land of Egypt (in March–April),[a] saying, 2 "Let the Israelites keep the Passover at its appointed time. 3 On the fourteenth day of this month (in March–April), at twilight,[b] you are to keep it at its appointed time. You are to keep it according to all its statutes and all its rules." 4 So Moses told the Israelites to keep the Passover. 5 They kept the Passover in the first month, on the fourteenth day of the month (in March–April), at

twilight, in the Wilderness of Sinai. According to all that Yahweh had commanded Moses, so the Israelites did.
6 Now there were certain men who were defiled by a dead body, so that they could not keep the Passover on that day; and they came before Moses and Aaron the same day, 7 and those men said to him, "We are unclean through contact with a dead person. Why should we be kept from presenting Yahweh's offering at its appointed time among the Israelites?" 8 Moses said to them, "Wait, so that I may hear what Yahweh will command concerning you."
9 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 10 "Speak to the Israelites and say: If any of you or your descendants are unclean from touching a dead body, or are on a distant journey, they may still keep the Passover to Yahweh.[c] 11 In the second month, on the fourteenth day (in April–May), at twilight, they are to keep it. They are to eat it with unleavened bread and bitter herbs. 12 They must leave none of it until morning or break any of its bones. They are to keep it according to all the statute of the Passover. 13 But the man who is clean and is not on a journey, and fails to keep the Passover, that person is to be cut off from his people, because he did not present Yahweh's offering at its appointed time. That man will bear his sin. 14 If a foreigner who lives among you wants to keep the Passover to Yahweh, he is to do so according to the statute of the Passover and according to its rule. You are to have one statute, both for the foreigner and for the native of the land.'"
15 On the day the tabernacle was set up, the cloud covered the tabernacle, the tent of the testimony. And from evening until morning it was over the tabernacle like the appearance of fire. 16 So it was continually: the cloud covered it by day,[d] and the appearance of fire by night. 17 Whenever the cloud was lifted from over the tent, after that the Israelites set out; and in the place where the cloud settled, there the Israelites camped. 18 At Yahweh's command the Israelites journeyed, and at Yahweh's command they pitched camp; as long as the cloud stayed over the tabernacle they remained in their camp. 19 Even when the cloud lingered over the tabernacle many days, the Israelites kept Yahweh's charge and did not set out. 20 Sometimes the

cloud was over the tabernacle a few days. At the command of Yahweh they remained in camp, and at the command of Yahweh they set out.
21 Sometimes the cloud stayed only from evening to morning, and whenever it lifted in the morning they journeyed on; or if it stayed a day and a night, they journeyed when it lifted. 22 Whether it was two days, a month, or a year[e] that the cloud stayed over the tabernacle, the Israelites remained camped and did not journey; but when it lifted, they journeyed. 23 At Yahweh's command they pitched camp, and at Yahweh's command they journeyed; they kept the charge of Yahweh, as Yahweh directed through Moses.

Notes

- a (9:1) The first month of Israel's religious calendar, which began in spring, was Abib, later called Nisan (Exodus 12:2; 13:4). Because the months were lunar, the dates fall in different parts of March and April from year to year. This is one month before the census of 1:1.
- b (9:3) Hebrew "between the two evenings," probably the time between sunset and dark. So also in verses 5 and 11. See the note at Exodus 12:6.
- c (9:10) This is the provision for a "second Passover" one month later, in the second month (Iyyar, also called Ziv).
- d (9:16) The Septuagint and other ancient versions read "by day." The traditional Hebrew text lacks the words.
- e (9:22) Hebrew yamim, "days," which can mean a year or an indefinite period.

Chapter 10

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Make two trumpets of silver. Make them of hammered work. You are to use them for summoning the congregation and for breaking camp. 3 When both are blown, the whole congregation is to gather to you at the entrance of the tent of meeting. 4 But if only one is sounded, the leaders, the heads of Israel's divisions,[a] shall gather before you. 5 When you sound an alarm,[b] the camps that are on the east side are to set out. 6 When you sound an alarm a second time, the camps that are on the south side are to set out. An alarm is to be sounded whenever they are to set out.[c] 7 But when the assembly is to be gathered, you are to blow, but not sound an alarm. 8 The sons of Aaron, the priests, shall blow the trumpets; and they shall be an ordinance forever to you throughout your generations. 9 When you go to war in your land against the enemy

who attacks you, you shall sound the alarm with the trumpets, and you will be remembered before Yahweh your God, and you will be delivered from your enemies. 10 On your days of gladness too, at your appointed feasts and the first of every month,[d] you shall blow the trumpets over your burnt offerings and your peace offering sacrifices; they shall be a memorial for you before your God: I am Yahweh your God."[e]

11 In the second year, in the second month, on the twentieth day of the month (in April–May),[f] the cloud was lifted from over the tabernacle of the testimony, 12 and the Israelites set out by stages from the Wilderness of Sinai. The cloud settled in the Wilderness of Paran. 13 They set out for the first time at the command of Yahweh through Moses. 14 The banner of the camp of the descendants of Judah set out first by their divisions, and over their army was Nahshon son of Amminadab. 15 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Issachar was Nethanel son of Zuar. 16 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Zebulun was Eliab son of Helon.

17 Then the tabernacle was taken apart, and Gershon's sons and Merari's sons, the bearers of the tabernacle, set out. 18 The banner of the camp of Reuben set out by their divisions, and over their army was Elizur son of Shedeur. 19 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Simeon was Shelumiel son of Zurishaddai. 20 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Gad was Eliasaph son of Deuel.

21 And the Kohathites moved out, bearing the sanctuary, so that the tabernacle could be set up by the time they arrived. 22 The banner of the camp of the descendants of Ephraim set out by their divisions, and over their army was Elishama son of Ammihud. 23 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh was Gamaliel son of Pedahzur. 24 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Benjamin was Abidan son of Gideoni.

25 Then the banner of the camp of the descendants of Dan, the rear guard of all the camps, set out by their divisions, and over their army was Ahiezer son of Ammishaddai. 26 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Asher was Pagiel son of Ochran. 27 Over the army of the tribe of the descendants of Naphtali was Ahira son of Enan. 28 This

was the order of march of the Israelites by their divisions when they set out.

29 Moses said to Hobab son of Reuel[g] the Midianite, Moses' father-in-law, "We are setting out for the place of which Yahweh said, 'I will give it to you.' Come with us, and we will treat you well, for Yahweh has promised good things to Israel." 30 But he said to him, "I will not go. I will go back to my own land and to my relatives." 31 And he said, "Please do not leave us, since you know how we are to encamp in the wilderness, and you can be our eyes. 32 And if you do go with us, then whatever good Yahweh gives us, we will share it with you."

33 So they set out from the mountain of Yahweh three days' journey. The ark of the covenant of Yahweh went before them three days' journey,[h] to seek out a resting place for them. 34 The cloud of Yahweh was over them by day when they set out from the camp.

35 Whenever the ark set out,[i] Moses would say, "Arise, Yahweh, and let your enemies be scattered, and let those who hate you flee before you." 36 And when it rested, he would say, "Return, Yahweh, to the countless thousands of Israel."[j]

Notes

- a (10:4) Or "clans." See the note at 1:16.
- b (10:5) Hebrew teruʿah, a loud blast or series of blasts, as distinct from an ordinary blowing of the trumpet.
- c (10:6) The Septuagint adds that at a third and a fourth alarm the camps on the west and on the north are to set out. The Hebrew lacks this.
- d (10:10) Hebrew "heads of your months," the new moon at the beginning of each lunar month.
- e (10:10) At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds a long passage taken from Deuteronomy 1:6–8, in which Yahweh commands Israel to leave Horeb and go into the hill country of the Amorites. Similar harmonizing expansions, drawn from Deuteronomy or from elsewhere in Numbers, occur in the Samaritan Pentateuch at 12:16; 13:33; 14:40, 45; 20:13; 21; 27:23; and 31:20. Several are also preserved in fragments of Numbers from the Dead Sea Scrolls. They are not found in the traditional Hebrew text and most are absent from the Septuagint.
- f (10:11) Second month: Iyyar, also called Ziv, of the spring-start religious calendar; because the months were lunar, the date falls in different parts of April and May. Israel had been at Sinai about eleven months (Exodus 19:1).

- g (10:29) Hobab means "beloved." Reuel means "friend of God." He is also called Jethro in Exodus 3:1; 18:1. Here it is not certain whether "Moses' father-in-law" refers to Hobab or to Reuel; Judges 4:11 calls Hobab Moses' father-in-law.
- h (10:33) The repetition of "three days' journey" is unusual; some interpreters suspect that the second occurrence arose from a copying error.
- i (10:35) In the traditional Hebrew text, verses 35–36 are set off by a reversed Hebrew letter nun before and after them, the so-called "inverted nuns." Ancient rabbis explained these marks as showing that the passage stands out of its proper place or forms a separate book. The Septuagint places verse 34 after verses 35–36.
- j (10:36) Or "Return, Yahweh, the countless thousands of Israel," that is, bring them back. Hebrew "ten thousands of thousands."

Chapter 11

1 Now the people became like those who complain of misfortune in
the hearing of Yahweh. When Yahweh heard it, his anger burned,
and the fire of Yahweh burned among them and consumed some of
the outskirts of the camp. 2 Then the people cried out to Moses, and
Moses prayed to Yahweh, and the fire died down. 3 So the name of
that place was called Taberah,[a] because the fire of Yahweh had burned
among them.
4 Now the rabble[b] among them began to crave other food; and the
Israelites also wept again and said, "Who will feed us meat? 5 We
remember the fish we used to eat free in Egypt, the cucumbers, the
melons, the leeks, the onions, and the garlic; 6 But now our throat
is dried up. There is nothing at all except this manna to look at." 7
The manna was like coriander seed, and its appearance was like the
appearance of bdellium.[c] 8 The people went about and gathered it,
ground it in mills or pounded it in mortars, boiled it in pots, and made
cakes of it. Its taste was like the taste of cakes baked with oil. 9 When
the dew fell on the camp at night, the manna fell with it.
10 Moses heard the people weeping, family by family, each at the
entrance of his tent. Yahweh's anger burned greatly, and in Moses'
eyes it was evil. 11 So Moses said to Yahweh, "Why have you dealt ill
with your servant? Why have I not found grace in your sight, that
you place the burden of this entire people on me? 12 Did I conceive
all these people? Did I bring them forth, that you should say to me,
'Carry them in your arms, as a nursing father carries a nursing infant,'

to the land you promised on oath to their ancestors? 13 Where would
I find meat to give this entire people? For they keep weeping to me,
saying, 'Give us meat to eat!' 14 I am not able to carry all this people
by myself; it is too heavy for me. 15 If this is how you deal with me,
kill me at once, I pray, if I have found favor in your sight, and do not
let me see my wretchedness."[d]
16 So Yahweh said to Moses, "Gather to me seventy men of the elders
of Israel, whom you know as the elders and officials of the people;
bring them to the tent of meeting, and have them stand there beside
you. 17 I will come down and speak with you there; then I will take
some of the Spirit[e] that is upon you and place it on them, and they
shall share the burden of the people with you, so that you do not carry
it alone. 18 And say to the people: 'Sanctify yourselves for tomorrow,
and you shall eat meat, because you have wept in Yahweh's hearing,
saying, "Who will feed us meat? For we were better off in Egypt!"
Therefore Yahweh will give you meat, and you shall eat. 19 You will
not eat it for one day, or two days, or five days, or ten days, or twenty
days, 20 but for a full month, until it comes out at your nostrils and
becomes loathsome to you, because you have rejected Yahweh who
is among you and have wept before him, saying, "Why did we ever
leave Egypt?"'" 21 And Moses said, "The people among whom I live
number six hundred thousand foot soldiers;[f] and yet you have said,
'I will give them meat, that they may eat for a full month.' 22 Should
flocks and herds be slaughtered for them, to be enough for them?
Or should all the fish of the sea be gathered together for them, to be
enough for them?" 23 Yahweh said to Moses, "Is Yahweh's hand too
short?[g] Now you will see whether my word will come true for you
or not."
24 So Moses went out and told the people the words of Yahweh. He
gathered seventy men of the elders of the people and had them stand
around the tent. 25 Then Yahweh came down in the cloud and spoke
to him, and took some of the Spirit that was on him and put it on the
seventy elders. When the Spirit rested on them, they prophesied, but
they did not do so again.[h]

26 Yet two men remained in the camp, one called Eldad and the
other Medad;[i] the Spirit settled on them, for they were among those
enrolled, though they had not gone out to the tent; and they proph-
esied in the camp. 27 A young man ran and told Moses, "Eldad and
Medad are prophesying in the camp." 28 Joshua son of Nun, Moses'
assistant from his youth,[j] answered, "My lord Moses, stop them!" 29
But Moses said to him, "Are you jealous for my sake? I wish that all
Yahweh's people were prophets, that Yahweh would put his Spirit on
them!" 30 And Moses and the elders of Israel returned to the camp.
31 Then a wind went out from Yahweh and brought quail from the
sea and let them fall beside the camp, about a day's journey on this
side and about a day's journey on the other side, all around the camp,
about 3 feet[k] above the ground. 32 And the people were up all that
day and all night and all the following day, gathering quail; the one
who gathered least had about 60 bushels.[l] And they spread them out
for themselves around the camp. 33 While the meat was still between
their teeth, before it was chewed, the anger of Yahweh burned
against the people, and Yahweh struck the people with a very great
plague. 34 So the name of that place was called Kibroth-hattaavah,[m]
because there they buried the people who had the craving. 35 From
Kibroth-hattaavah the people set out for Hazeroth, and they stayed
at Hazeroth.

Notes

- a (11:3) Taberah means "burning."
- b (11:4) Hebrew 'asafsuf, a rare word for a gathered crowd, probably the non-Israelites who left Egypt with them (Exodus 12:38).
- c (11:7) Hebrew bedolakh, probably a pale, translucent resin. Compare Genesis 2:12.
- d (11:15) Ancient scribal tradition lists this as one of the "corrections of the scribes": the text originally read "your misery" (that is, the wrong done to Moses by Yahweh), and was changed for reverence.
- e (11:17) Or "spirit." So also in verses 25, 26, and 29.
- f (11:21) The round figure corresponds to the census total of 603,550 (1:46). On the meaning of the figures, see the note at 1:46.
- g (11:23) That is, is Yahweh's power limited?
- h (11:25) Or "but they did not stop." The Hebrew verb is ambiguous; the Targums and the Vulgate read "and they did not cease."

- i (11:26) Eldad means “God has loved.” Medad perhaps means “beloved.”
- j (11:28) Or “one of his chosen men.” The Septuagint reads “the chosen one.”
- k (11:31) Or “about two cubits deep,” meaning that the quail flew about 3 feet (90 centimeters) above the ground, or that they lay in heaps of that depth. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters).
- l (11:32) Hebrew “ten homers,” about 2,200 liters. A homer was about 6 bushels (220 liters); standards varied.
- m (11:34) Kibroth-hattaavah means “graves of craving.”

Chapter 12

1 Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses because of the Cushite[a] woman whom he had married, for he had married a Cushite woman.
2 They said, “Has Yahweh spoken only through Moses? Has he not also spoken through us?” And Yahweh heard it. 3 Now the man Moses was very humble,[b] more than all the people who were on the face of the earth.
4 Suddenly Yahweh spoke to Moses, Aaron, and Miriam: “Come out, you three, to the tent of meeting!” So the three of them came out. 5 Yahweh came down in a pillar of cloud and stood at the entrance of the tent and called Aaron and Miriam, and they both came forward. 6 He said, “Hear my words: If there is a prophet among you, I, Yahweh, make myself known to him in a vision; I speak with him in a dream. 7 Not so with my servant Moses. He is faithful in all my house. 8 With him I speak mouth to mouth, visibly and not in riddles, and the form of Yahweh he beholds. Why then did you not fear to speak against my servant Moses?” 9 And the anger of Yahweh burned against them, and he departed.
10 When the cloud moved away from over the tent, there was Miriam with a skin disease, white as snow.[c] Aaron turned toward Miriam, and there she was with a skin disease. 11 Aaron said to Moses, “Oh, my lord, please do not hold against us the sin that we have so foolishly committed and the wrong we have done. 12 Please do not let her be like a stillborn child, whose flesh is half eaten away when it comes out of its mother’s womb.”[d] 13 And Moses cried out to Yahweh, saying, “O God, please heal her, please.”

14 But Yahweh said to Moses, “If her father had only spat in her face,
would she not be in disgrace for seven days? Let her be shut outside
the camp for seven days, and afterward she may be brought back in.”
15 So Miriam was shut outside the camp for seven days, and the people
did not set out until Miriam was brought back. 16 After that the people
set out from Hazeroth and camped in the Wilderness of Paran.[e]

Notes

- a (12:1) Cush was the region south of Egypt (ancient Nubia). Some identify the woman with Zipporah, whose people were from Midian (Exodus 2:21), linking Cush with Cushan (Habakkuk 3:7); others think of a second wife.
- b (12:3) Or “meek.” Hebrew ‘anav, one who is lowly and dependent on God rather than self-assertive.
- c (12:10) That is, flaky or white like snow. On the Hebrew term for skin disease, see the note at 5:2.
- d (12:12) Ancient scribal tradition lists “her mother’s womb … her flesh” here as a “correction of the scribes” for an original “our mother’s womb … our flesh.”
- e (12:16) At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 1:20–23, introducing the sending of the spies. See the note at 10:10.

Chapter 13

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 “Send out men to explore the land
of Canaan, which I am giving to the Israelites. From each tribe of
their fathers you are to send a man, every one a leader among them.”
3 So Moses sent them from the Wilderness of Paran at the command
of Yahweh. All of them were men who were heads of the Israelites. 4
These were their names: from the tribe of Reuben, Shammua son of
Zaccur; 5 from the tribe of Simeon, Shaphat son of Hori; 6 from the
tribe of Judah, Caleb son of Jephunneh;[a] 7 from the tribe of Issachar,
Igal son of Joseph; 8 from the tribe of Ephraim, Hoshea son of Nun;
9 from the tribe of Benjamin, Palti son of Raphu; 10 from the tribe of
Zebulun, Gaddiel son of Sodi; 11 from the tribe of Joseph, namely the
tribe of Manasseh, Gaddi the son of Susi; 12 from the tribe of Dan,
Ammiel son of Gemalli; 13 from the tribe of Asher, Sethur son of
Michael; 14 from the tribe of Naphtali, Nahbi son of Vophsi; 15 from the
tribe of Gad, Geuel son of Machi. 16 These are the names of the men
Moses sent to spy out the land. And Moses called Hoshea the son of
Nun, Joshua.[b]

17 When Moses sent them to spy out the land of Canaan, he said to
them, "Go up this way into the Negev,[c] and go up to the mountains,
18 and see what the land is like, and whether the people who live in it
are strong or weak, few or many, 19 and what the land is like where
they live, good or bad; and whether the towns they inhabit are camps
or fortresses; 20 and whether the soil is rich or poor, and if there are
woods in it or none. Take courage, and fetch some of the land's fruit."
It was the season of the first ripe grapes.[d]
21 So they went up and explored the land from the Wilderness of Zin
as far as Rehob, near Lebo-hamath.[e] 22 And they went up through
the Negev and came to Hebron, where Ahiman, Sheshai, and Talmai,
the descendants of Anak,[f] lived. (Now Hebron was built seven years
before Zoan in Egypt.) 23 They came to the Valley of Eshcol[g] and from
there cut off a branch bearing a single cluster of grapes, and two of
them carried it on a pole; they also brought some of the pomegranates
and figs. 24 That place was named the Valley of Eshcol on account of
the cluster the Israelites cut from it.
25 At the end of forty days they returned from exploring the land. 26
They came to Moses and Aaron and to the whole congregation of the
Israelites in the Wilderness of Paran, at Kadesh. They brought back
word to them and to the whole congregation and showed them the
fruit of the land. 27 They told him, "We went into the land to which
you sent us. It does flow with milk and honey, and this is its fruit. 28
However, the people who live in the land are strong, and the cities are
fortified and very large. We also saw the descendants of Anak there.
29 The Amalekites dwell in the Negev; the Hittites, the Jebusites, and
the Amorites dwell in the hill country; and the Canaanites dwell by
the sea and along the Jordan."
30 Then Caleb silenced the people before Moses and said, "We should
go up at once and take possession, for we are fully able to conquer
it." 31 But the men who had gone up with him said, "We are not able
to go up against the people, for they are stronger than we are." 32 And
they gave the Israelites a bad report of the land they had spied out,
saying, "The land through which we went to spy it out devours those
who live in it, and all the people we saw in it are of great stature. 33

There we saw the Nephilim[h] (the descendants of Anak come from the Nephilim), and we seemed like grasshoppers in our own eyes, and so we seemed in their eyes."[i]

Notes

- a (13:6) Many names in this list are found only here; their meanings are uncertain. Caleb may mean "dog," perhaps in the sense of a faithful servant. Shammua means "heard"; Shaphat, "he has judged"; Igal, "he redeems"; Hoshea, "salvation"; Gaddiel, "God is my fortune"; Ammiel, "my kinsman is God"; Michael, "who is like God?"
- b (13:16) Hoshea means "salvation." Joshua (Hebrew Yehoshua') means "Yahweh is salvation."
- c (13:17) Hebrew negev, "dry land," the arid region in the south of Canaan.
- d (13:20) That is, July–August.
- e (13:21) Or "Lebo of Hamath," or "the entrance of Hamath," at the northern limit of the land.
- f (13:22) Or "the Anakim," a people remembered for their great height. The name Anak may mean "long-necked." Ahiman perhaps means "my brother is a gift"; Sheshai and Talmai are of uncertain meaning.
- g (13:23) Eshcol means "cluster."
- h (13:33) Hebrew nefilim, perhaps "fallen ones." Compare Genesis 6:4. The Septuagint translates "giants."
- i (13:33) At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 1:27–33. See the note at 10:10.

Chapter 14

1 Then the whole congregation raised a loud cry, and the people wept
that night. 2 All the Israelites grumbled against Moses and Aaron, and
the whole congregation said to them, "If only we had died in the land
of Egypt! Or if only we had died in this wilderness! 3 Why is Yahweh
bringing us to this land only to die by the sword? Our wives and
children will be taken as spoil. Would we not be better off returning
to Egypt?" 4 And they said to one another, "Let us appoint a leader
and go back to Egypt."
5 Then Moses and Aaron fell on their faces before the whole assembly
of the congregation of the Israelites. 6 And Joshua son of Nun and
Caleb son of Jephunneh, who were among those who had explored
the land, tore their clothes 7 and said to the whole congregation of
the Israelites, "The land that we passed through to explore it is an
exceedingly good land. 8 If Yahweh delights in us, he will bring us into

this land and give it to us, a land that flows with milk and honey. 9
Only, do not rebel against Yahweh, and do not be afraid of the people
of the land, for we will devour them like bread. Their shelter[a] is gone
from them, and Yahweh is with us; do not be afraid of them." 10 But
the whole congregation talked of stoning them with stones. Then
the glory of Yahweh appeared in the tent of meeting before all the
Israelites.
11 And Yahweh said to Moses, "How long will these people treat me
with contempt? How long will they refuse to trust me, despite all the
signs I have performed among them? 12 I will strike them with plague
and dispossess them, and I will make you into a nation greater and
stronger than they."
13 And Moses said to Yahweh, "Then the Egyptians will hear of it—for
with your might you brought up this people from their midst— 14 and
they will tell it to the inhabitants of this land. They have heard that
you, Yahweh, are among this people, for you, Yahweh, are seen eye
to eye, and your cloud stands over them, and you go before them in
a pillar of cloud by day and in a pillar of fire by night. 15 Now if you
kill this people as one man, then the nations who have heard your
fame will say, 16 'Because Yahweh was not able to bring this people
into the land that he swore to give them, he has slaughtered them in
the wilderness.' 17 And now, I pray, let my Lord's power be great,[b] as
you have declared: 18 'Yahweh is long-suffering and rich in steadfast
love,[c] forgiving iniquity and transgression, yet he does not clear the
guilty, but visits the iniquity of the fathers on the children, on the
third and the fourth generation.' 19 Pardon the iniquity of this people,
I pray, in keeping with the greatness of your steadfast love, as you
have forgiven them from the time of Egypt until now."
20 Yahweh said, "I have pardoned, as you asked. 21 But truly, as I live,
and as all the earth will be filled with the glory of Yahweh, 22 because
all those men who have seen my glory and my signs which I did in
Egypt and in the wilderness, yet have put me to the proof ten times
and have not heeded my voice, 23 will see the land that I swore to give
to their fathers. None of those who despised me will see it. 24 But my
servant Caleb, because he has a different spirit and has followed me

fully, I will bring into the land into which he went, and his descendants will possess it. 25 Now the Amalekites and the Canaanites live in the valleys. Tomorrow turn and set out for the wilderness by the way of the Red Sea."[d]
26 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 27 "How long shall I bear with this wicked congregation that grumbles against me? I have heard the grumblings of the Israelites, which they grumble against me. 28 Say to them, 'As I live, declares Yahweh, I will do to you just as you have spoken in my hearing. 29 Your dead bodies will fall in this wilderness, all of you who were counted in your whole number, from twenty years old and upward, who have grumbled against me. 30 Not one of you will come into the land where I swore[e] to settle you, except Caleb son of Jephunneh and Joshua son of Nun. 31 But your little ones, whom you said would become spoil, I will bring in, and they shall know the land you have despised. 32 But as for you, your dead bodies will fall in this wilderness. 33 Your children will be shepherds in the wilderness forty years and will suffer for your unfaithfulness,[f] until the last of your dead bodies lies in the wilderness. 34 According to the number of the days you spied out the land—forty days, a day for each year—you shall bear your guilt forty years, and you shall know what it is to have me against you.'[g] 35 I, Yahweh, have said it; I will surely do this to all this evil congregation that has banded together against me. In this wilderness they shall be finished, and there they shall die."
36 As for the men whom Moses sent to spy out the land, who came back and made the whole congregation complain against him by spreading a bad report about the land, 37 the men who brought the bad report about the land died by a plague before Yahweh. 38 But Joshua the son of Nun and Caleb the son of Jephunneh remained alive of those men who went to spy out the land.
39 When Moses told these words to all the Israelites, the people mourned greatly. 40 They rose early in the morning and went up to the top of the hill country, saying, "Here we are. We will go up to the place that Yahweh has promised, for we have sinned."[h] 41 But Moses said, "Why are you transgressing the command of Yahweh? It will not succeed. 42 Do not go up, for Yahweh is not in your midst; you will be

defeated by your enemies. 43 For the Amalekites and the Canaanites
are facing you there, and you shall fall by the sword; because you have
turned away from Yahweh, Yahweh will not be with you." 44 But they
dared to go up toward the crest of the hill country, though neither
the ark of Yahweh's covenant nor Moses left the camp. 45 Then the
Amalekites and the Canaanites who lived in that hill country came
down and struck them and crushed them as far as Hormah.[i]

Notes

- a (14:9) Hebrew "their shadow," that is, the protection of their gods.
- b (14:17) In the traditional Hebrew text the first letter of the word for "be great" is written larger than normal, a scribal feature with no certain meaning.
- c (14:18) Hebrew khesed, covenant loyalty and love. Verses 18–19 echo Exodus 34:6–7.
- d (14:25) Hebrew yam suf, "Sea of Reeds." Here it probably refers to the Gulf of Aqaba. See the note at Exodus 10:19.
- e (14:30) Hebrew "lifted my hand," a gesture of swearing an oath.
- f (14:33) Hebrew "bear your whoredoms," a common biblical image for unfaithfulness to God.
- g (14:34) Or "what it means to have me against you." The Hebrew word is rare.
- h (14:40) At this point and after verse 45 the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 1–2. See the note at 10:10.
- i (14:45) Hormah means "destruction" or "devoted to destruction." Compare 21:3.

Chapter 15

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Speak to the Israelites and tell
them: When you enter the land of your dwellings, which I am giving
you, 3 and you present a fire offering to Yahweh from the herd or the
flock, whether a burnt offering or a sacrifice, in fulfillment of a vow,
or as a freewill offering, or on your appointed feast days, to produce
a pleasing aroma for Yahweh, 4 then the one who brings his offering
is to present to Yahweh a grain offering of about 2 quarts of fine flour
mixed with about 1 quart of oil.[a] 5 You are also to prepare about 1
quart of wine for the drink offering with the burnt offering or for
the sacrifice, for each lamb. 6 For a ram you are to prepare as a grain
offering about 4 quarts of fine flour mixed with about 1⅓ quarts of
oil.[b] 7 And for the drink offering you are to present about 1⅓ quarts of
wine, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 8 When you prepare a young bull

as a burnt offering or a sacrifice, to fulfill a vow, or as peace offerings to Yahweh, 9 then one is to present with the young bull a grain offering of about 6 quarts of fine flour mixed with about 2 quarts of oil.[c] 10 And you are to present for the drink offering about 2 quarts of wine, as an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh.
11 "This is how it shall be done for each ox, for each ram, for each male lamb, or for each kid. 12 According to the number that you prepare, so you are to do with each one, according to their number. 13 "All who are native-born shall do these things in this manner, when they present a fire offering of pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 14 And if a foreigner is living with you, or anyone who is among you throughout your generations, and he wants to present an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh, he is to do as you do. 15 As for the assembly, there shall be one statute for you and for the stranger living with you—a perpetual statute throughout your generations; the stranger shall be as you are before Yahweh. 16 One law and one rule is to apply to you and to the foreigner who lives with you.'"
17 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 18 "Speak to the Israelites and tell them: When you come to the land where I am bringing you, 19 and you eat of the bread of the land, you are to present a contribution to Yahweh. 20 You shall offer up a cake from the first of your dough[d] as a contribution; as you do with the contribution of the threshing floor, so you shall offer it. 21 From the first of your dough you are to give to Yahweh a contribution throughout your generations.
22 "'But if you unintentionally fail and do not keep all these commandments that Yahweh has spoken to Moses, 23 all that Yahweh has commanded you through Moses, from the day that Yahweh gave commandment and onward throughout your generations, 24 then it shall be, if it was done in error, without the congregation's knowledge, that the whole congregation shall offer one young bull for a burnt offering, as a pleasing aroma to Yahweh, with its grain offering and its drink offering, according to the ordinance, and one male goat for a sin offering. 25 So the priest shall make atonement for the entire congregation of the Israelites, and it shall be forgiven them, for it was an error; they shall bring their offering, a fire offering to

Yahweh, and their sin offering before Yahweh, on account of their error. 26 The whole congregation of the Israelites will be forgiven, and the foreigner who lives among them, because the whole people was involved in the mistake.

27 "'If one person sins unintentionally, he is to offer a female goat a year old as a sin offering. 28 And the priest shall make atonement for the person who errs when he sins by mistake before Yahweh, making atonement for him; and he shall be forgiven. 29 You are to have one law for the one who acts unintentionally, both for the native among the Israelites and for the foreigner who lives among them. 30 But the person who acts with a high hand,[e] whether native or foreigner, is blaspheming Yahweh, and that person is to be cut off from among his people. 31 Because he has despised Yahweh's word and broken his commandment, that person shall be utterly cut off; his guilt shall be upon him.'"

32 While the Israelites were in the wilderness, they found a man gathering wood on the Sabbath day. 33 Those who found him gathering wood brought him to Moses and Aaron and to the whole congregation. 34 They placed him in custody, because it had not been declared what should be done to him. 35 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "The man shall surely be put to death; all the congregation shall stone him with stones outside the camp." 36 So the whole congregation brought him outside the camp and stoned him with stones, and he died, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

37 Yahweh said to Moses, 38 "Speak to the Israelites and instruct them to make tassels[f] on the corners of their garments throughout their generations, putting a blue[g] cord on the tassel of each corner. 39 And it shall be a tassel for you to gaze upon and so remember all of Yahweh's commandments and do them, rather than follow the desires of your own heart and your own eyes, which lead you to unfaithfulness. 40 So you will remember and do all my commandments, and be holy to your God. 41 I am Yahweh your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt to be your God. I am Yahweh your God."

Notes

- a (15:4) Hebrew “a tenth of fine flour mixed with a quarter of a hin of oil,” about 2.2 liters of flour and 0.9 liter of oil. The tenth is a tenth of an ephah; an ephah was about three-fifths of a bushel (22 liters), and a hin about 1 gallon (3.7 liters). Standards varied. So also with the wine in verse 5.
- b (15:6) Hebrew “two-tenths of fine flour mixed with a third of a hin of oil,” about 4.4 liters of flour and 1.2 liters of oil. So also with the wine in verse 7.
- c (15:9) Hebrew “three-tenths of fine flour mixed with half a hin of oil,” about 6.6 liters of flour and 1.9 liters of oil. So also with the wine in verse 10.
- d (15:20) Or “coarse meal.” The Hebrew word ‘arisah is uncertain.
- e (15:30) That is, defiantly and deliberately.
- f (15:38) Hebrew tsitsit, a tassel or fringe.
- g (15:38) Hebrew tekhelet, a blue or violet dye made from murex shellfish.

Chapter 16

1 Now Korah son of Izhar, son of Kohath, son of Levi, took men,[a]
together with Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab, and On son of
Peleth, sons of Reuben.[b] 2 They rose up before Moses, together with
two hundred fifty men of the Israelites, leaders of the congregation,
chosen from the assembly, men of renown. 3 They assembled against
Moses and against Aaron and said to them, “You have gone too far!
For all the congregation is holy, every one of them, and Yahweh is
among them. Why then do you exalt yourselves above the assembly
of Yahweh?”
4 When Moses heard it, he fell on his face. 5 And he said to Korah and
all his company, “Tomorrow morning Yahweh will show who is his,
and who is holy, and he will cause that one to come near him; the one
he chooses he will cause to come near him. 6 Do this: take censers,
Korah and all his company, 7 and tomorrow put fire in them and put
incense on them before Yahweh. The man whom Yahweh chooses,
he is the holy one. You have gone too far, sons of Levi!” 8 And Moses
said to Korah, “Hear now, you sons of Levi: 9 Is it too little for you
that the God of Israel has distinguished you from the rest of Israel’s
community, drawing you near to himself for the labor of Yahweh’s
tabernacle, and appointing you to stand before the community to
serve them, 10 and that he has brought you near, and all your brothers
the sons of Levi with you? Would you seek the priesthood also? 11
Therefore it is against Yahweh that you and all your company have

gathered together. As for Aaron, who is he, that you grumble against him?"
12 Moses sent to call Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab, but they said, "We will not come up. 13 Is it not enough that you have brought us up out of a land flowing with milk and honey to kill us in the wilderness, but you would also make yourself a ruler over us? 14 Moreover, you have not brought us into a land flowing with milk and honey, nor given us an inheritance of fields and vineyards. Will you gouge out the eyes of these men?[c] We will not come up." 15 Moses was very angry and said to Yahweh, "Do not respect their offering. I have not taken a single donkey from them, and I have not harmed one of them." 16 And Moses said to Korah, "You and all your company, be present before Yahweh tomorrow, you and they and Aaron. 17 Let each man take his censer and put incense on it, and each bring his censer before Yahweh—two hundred and fifty censers; you also, and Aaron, each with his censer." 18 So each man took his censer, put fire in them, laid incense on them, and stood at the entrance of the tent of meeting with Moses and Aaron. 19 And Korah gathered the whole congregation against them at the door of the tent of meeting; then the glory of Yahweh appeared to the whole congregation.
20 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 21 "Separate yourselves from among this congregation, so that I may consume them in a moment." 22 But they fell on their faces and said, "O God, the God of the spirits of all flesh, shall one man sin, and will you be angry with the whole congregation?"
23 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 24 "Speak to the congregation, saying, 'Get away from around the dwelling of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram.'" 25 Then Moses rose and went to Dathan and Abiram, and the elders of Israel followed him. 26 And he spoke to the congregation, saying, "Move away, I urge you, from the tents of these wicked men, and touch nothing that belongs to them, or you will be swept away with all their sins." 27 So they got away from around the dwelling of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram. Dathan and Abiram came out and stood at the entrance of their tents, with their wives, their sons, and their little ones.

28 And Moses said, “By this you shall know that Yahweh has sent me
to do all these works, for they are not of my own devising.[d] 29 If these
men die as all people die, or if they are visited by the fate of all people,
then Yahweh has not sent me. 30 But if Yahweh creates something new,
and the ground opens its mouth and swallows them up with all that
belongs to them, and they go down alive into Sheol,[e] then you will
know that these men have despised Yahweh.”
31 Now as he finished speaking all these words, the ground beneath
them split open, 32 and the earth opened its mouth and swallowed
them up, together with their households, and all Korah’s people[f] and
all their goods. 33 So they and all that belonged to them went down
alive into Sheol, and the earth closed over them, and they perished
from the midst of the assembly. 34 All Israel who were around them
fled at their cry, for they said, “The earth might swallow us up!” 35
And fire came out from Yahweh and consumed the two hundred fifty
men who were offering the incense.
36 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying,[g] 37 “Tell Eleazar son of Aaron the
priest to take up the censers out of the blaze, and scatter the fire far
away, for they have become holy. 38 As for the censers of these sinners
who have forfeited their lives, let them be hammered into plating
to cover the altar, since they offered them before Yahweh and they
became holy; and they shall be a sign to the Israelites.” 39 So Eleazar
the priest took the bronze censers that those who were burned had
presented, and they were hammered out as a covering for the altar, 40
as a memorial to the Israelites, that no stranger who is not a descen-
dant of Aaron may approach to burn incense before Yahweh, or he
will become like Korah and his company, just as Yahweh had said to
him through Moses.
41 But on the next day the whole congregation of the Israelites grum-
bled against Moses and against Aaron, saying, “You have killed the
people of Yahweh.” 42 When the congregation had gathered against
Moses and Aaron, they turned toward the tent of meeting; and be-
hold, the cloud covered it, and the glory of Yahweh appeared. 43 Moses
and Aaron came to the front of the tent of meeting, 44 and Yahweh
spoke to Moses, saying, 45 “Get away from the midst of this congre-

gation, so that I may consume them in a moment." And they fell on their faces. 46 So Moses said to Aaron, "Take your censer and put fire in it from the altar, lay incense on it, go quickly to the congregation and make atonement for them; for wrath has gone out from Yahweh, and the plague has begun." 47 So Aaron took it as Moses had said and ran into the midst of the assembly. And the plague had already begun among the people. He put on the incense and made atonement for the people. 48 He stood between the dead and the living, and the plague was stopped. 49 Now those who died in the plague numbered 14,700, besides those who died because of Korah. 50 So Aaron went back to Moses at the door of the tent of meeting, for the plague had been stopped.

Notes

- a (16:1) Or "took action," or "became insolent." The Hebrew has no object, and the meaning is uncertain.
- b (16:1) Korah perhaps means "bald." Izhar means "shining." Dathan is of uncertain meaning. Abiram means "my father is exalted." On means "strength" or "wealth." Peleth perhaps means "swiftness."
- c (16:14) That is, will you blind them to what you are doing?
- d (16:28) Hebrew "from my heart."
- e (16:30) Sheol is the realm of the dead, pictured as beneath the earth. So also in verse 33.
- f (16:32) According to 26:11, the sons of Korah did not die.
- g (16:36) In the Hebrew text, verses 36–50 are numbered 17:1–15.

Chapter 17

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying,[a] 2 "Speak to the Israelites, and take from them one staff for each ancestral house, from all their leaders by their ancestral houses: twelve staffs. Write each man's name on his staff. 3 Write Aaron's name on the staff of Levi. For there is to be one staff for the head of each father's house. 4 You are to deposit them in the tent of meeting before the testimony, where I meet with you. 5 And the staff of the man whom I choose will sprout. So I will stop the grumblings of the Israelites, which they grumble against you, from coming before me." 6 So Moses spoke to the Israelites, and each of their leaders gave him a staff apiece, one for each leader, according to their ancestral houses—twelve staffs; and Aaron's staff was among

their staffs. 7 And Moses deposited the staffs before Yahweh in the tent of the testimony.
8 The next day Moses entered the tent of the testimony, and there the staff of Aaron for the house of Levi had sprouted, putting forth buds, bursting into blossom, and bearing ripe almonds. 9 Then Moses brought out all the staffs from before Yahweh to all the Israelites. They looked, and each man took his staff. 10 Yahweh said to Moses, "Put Aaron's staff back in front of the testimony, to be kept as a sign for the rebels, so that their murmuring against me may come to an end, and they will not die." 11 Moses did so. As Yahweh commanded him, so he did.
12 The Israelites said to Moses, "Look, we perish, we are undone, all of us are undone! 13 Whoever comes near, anyone who comes near to the tabernacle of Yahweh, must die. Shall we all perish?"

Notes

- a (17:1) In the Hebrew text, verses 1–13 are numbered 17:16–28.

Chapter 18

1 Yahweh said to Aaron, "You and your sons and your father's house with you are to bear the iniquity connected with the sanctuary, and you and your sons with you are to bear the iniquity connected with your priesthood. 2 And bring with you also your kinsmen, the tribe of Levi, your ancestral tribe, so that they may attach themselves to you[a] and serve you, while you and your sons are before the tent of the testimony. 3 They shall attend to your needs and to the needs of the whole tent; only they shall not come near the vessels of the sanctuary or the altar, lest they and you also die. 4 They shall be joined with you and attend to the tent of meeting, for all the service of the tent; but no stranger shall come near you. 5 You are to keep guard over the sanctuary and over the altar, so that there may never again be wrath on the Israelites. 6 For I myself have taken your kinsmen the Levites from among the Israelites; to you they are a gift, given over to Yahweh, to labor at the tent of meeting. 7 But you and your sons with you are to guard your priesthood in everything concerning the altar and what is inside the veil, and you are to serve. I give you your

priesthood as a gift of service, and any outsider who comes near is to be put to death."
8 Then Yahweh spoke to Aaron: "See, I have placed you in charge of my contributions, all the holy gifts of the Israelites. To you I have assigned them as a portion,[b] and to your sons as a perpetual share.
9 This is to be yours from the most holy things, kept back from the fire: every offering of theirs, every grain offering, every sin offering, and every guilt offering that they render to me, is to be most holy for you and for your sons. 10 You shall eat it as something most holy; every male may eat it. Consider it holy. 11 This also is yours: the gift they set aside, all the wave offerings of the Israelites; I have given them to you, and to your sons and daughters with you, as a perpetual share; whoever in your house is clean may eat of it. 12 All the finest of the oil, the finest of the new wine and of the grain, the firstfruits that they give to Yahweh, I have given to you. 13 The first ripe fruits of all that is in their land, which they bring to Yahweh, are to be yours. Everyone in your house who is clean may eat it. 14 Everything devoted[c] in Israel is to be yours. 15 Everything that opens the womb of all flesh, which they present to Yahweh, both of people and of animals, is to be yours. Nevertheless, you must surely redeem the firstborn of people, and you are to redeem the firstborn of unclean animals.
16 Their redemption price, from a month old, you are to fix at about 2 ounces of silver,[d] by the sanctuary standard. 17 But the firstborn of a cow, or the firstborn of a sheep, or the firstborn of a goat, you must not redeem. They are holy. You are to sprinkle their blood on the altar and burn their fat as an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. 18 But their flesh is to be yours, just as the breast that is waved and the right thigh are yours. 19 All the holy contributions that the Israelites present to Yahweh I have given to you, and to your sons and daughters with you, as a permanent due. It is a covenant of salt[e] forever before Yahweh for you and for your descendants with you."
20 And Yahweh said to Aaron, "You are to have no inheritance in their land, nor any portion among them. I am your portion and your inheritance among the Israelites.

21 “And to the sons of Levi I have given all the tithes in Israel for an
inheritance, in exchange for the work they perform, the work of the
tent of meeting. 22 The Israelites must no longer come near the tent
of meeting, lest they bear sin and die. 23 But the Levites shall perform
the work of the tent of meeting, and they shall bear their own guilt; it
shall be a perpetual statute throughout your generations, and among
the Israelites they shall have no inheritance. 24 For the Israelites’ tithes,
which they offer to Yahweh as a contribution, I have given to the
Levites for an inheritance; that is why I told them that among the
Israelites they shall have no inheritance.”
25 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 26 “Speak to the Levites and tell
them: Whenever you receive from the Israelites the tithe I have given
you from them as your inheritance, you shall set apart a contribution
from it for Yahweh, a tenth of the tithe. 27 And your contribution
shall be reckoned to you as though it were the grain of the threshing
floor or the fullness of the winepress. 28 So you also are to present
a contribution to Yahweh from all your tithes that you receive from
the Israelites, and from them you are to give Yahweh’s contribution
to Aaron the priest. 29 From all the gifts to you, you are to present
every contribution due to Yahweh, from all the best of them, the holy
part from them.’ 30 Therefore you shall say to them: ‘When you have
offered up the best of it, it shall be reckoned to the Levites as the yield
of the threshing floor and as the yield of the winepress. 31 You may
eat it in any place, you and your households, for it is your wages in
return for your service in the tent of meeting. 32 You will bear no sin
because of it, when you have presented the best of it. But you must
not profane the holy things of the Israelites, lest you die.’”

Notes

- a (18:2) The Hebrew verb for “be joined” (lavah) sounds like the name Levi. So also in verse 4.
- b (18:8) Or “because of the anointing.” The Hebrew word is uncertain.
- c (18:14) Hebrew kherem, something irrevocably given over to God, either for destruction or for the sanctuary’s use.
- d (18:16) Hebrew “five shekels,” about 57 grams. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); standards varied. The text adds that the shekel is twenty gerahs; a gerah was one-twentieth of a shekel.

- e (18:19) That is, a permanent and binding covenant. Salt, which preserves, was used in sealing agreements.

Chapter 19

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Aaron, saying, 2 “This is the requirement of the law that Yahweh has commanded: Tell the Israelites to bring you a red heifer[a] that is flawless, with no blemish, one that has never borne a yoke. 3 You are to give it to Eleazar the priest, and it is to be taken outside the camp and slaughtered in his presence. 4 Eleazar the priest shall take some of its blood on his finger, and sprinkle it directly in front of the tent of meeting seven times. 5 Then the heifer shall be burned in his sight: its hide, its flesh, and its blood, with its dung, shall be burned. 6 The priest is to take cedarwood, hyssop, and scarlet yarn and throw them into the midst of the burning heifer. 7 Then the priest shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in water; after that he may enter the camp, but the priest remains unclean until evening. 8 The one who burns it is to wash his clothes in water and bathe his body in water, and he will be unclean until evening. 9 Then a clean man shall collect the heifer’s ashes and lay them in a clean place outside the camp; they shall be kept in reserve for the Israelite community, to prepare the water of impurity.[b] It is a sin purification. 10 And the man who collects the heifer’s ashes shall wash his clothes and be unclean until evening. This is a lasting statute for the Israelites and for the stranger residing among them.

11 “Whoever touches the dead body of any person will be unclean seven days. 12 On the third day he shall purify himself with it, and on the seventh he shall be clean; but if he does not purify himself on the third and seventh days, he shall not be clean. 13 Whoever touches a dead person, the body of anyone who has died, and does not purify himself, defiles the tabernacle of Yahweh, and that person is to be cut off from Israel. Because the water for impurity was not thrown on him, he is unclean. His uncleanness is still on him.

14 “This is the law for when someone dies in a tent: anyone entering the tent, and anyone already in it, shall be unclean for seven days; 15 and every open container, with no lid fastened on it, is unclean. 16

Whoever in the open field touches one slain with a sword, or a body that died of itself, or a human bone, or a grave, shall be unclean seven days. 17 For the unclean person they shall take some ashes from the burnt sin purification, and pour fresh running water[c] over them in a vessel. 18 Then a clean person shall take hyssop, dip it in the water, and sprinkle the tent, all its furnishings, the people who were in it, and whoever touched the bone, the murder victim, the corpse, or the grave. 19 On the third day and again on the seventh the clean person shall sprinkle the unclean; on the seventh day he shall purify him, and the man shall wash his clothes and bathe in water, and by evening he will be clean.
20 "But whoever is unclean and fails to purify himself shall be cut off from the assembly, since he has defiled Yahweh's sanctuary. The water of impurity was never sprinkled on him; he remains unclean. 21 This is a lasting statute for them. The one who sprinkles the water of impurity shall wash his clothes, and whoever touches the water of impurity shall be unclean until evening. 22 Whatever the unclean person touches will be unclean, and the person who touches it will be unclean until evening."

Notes

- a (19:2) Or "a red cow." The Hebrew word parah denotes a young female of the herd; its reddish-brown color may evoke blood.
- b (19:9) Hebrew me niddah, "water of impurity," water used to remove impurity. So also in verses 13, 20, and 21.
- c (19:17) Hebrew "living water," that is, water from a flowing source.

Chapter 20

1 The Israelites, the whole congregation, came into the Wilderness of Zin in the first month (in March–April),[a] and the people stayed at Kadesh. Miriam died there and was buried there.
2 There was no water for the congregation, and they assembled against Moses and against Aaron. 3 The people quarreled with Moses and said, "If only we had died when our brothers died before Yahweh! 4 Why have you brought the assembly of Yahweh into this wilderness, that we and our livestock should die here? 5 And why did you bring us up from Egypt to this miserable place? Nothing grows here—no grain,

no figs, no vines, no pomegranates—and there is no water to drink."
6 Then Moses and Aaron went from the presence of the assembly to
the entrance of the tent of meeting and fell on their faces. And the
glory of Yahweh appeared to them.
7 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 8 "Take the staff and assemble the
congregation, you and your brother Aaron, and tell the rock in their
sight to give its water; so you will bring water out of the rock for them
and give the congregation and their animals something to drink." 9
Moses took the staff from before Yahweh, as he had commanded him.
10 Moses and Aaron assembled the congregation in front of the rock,
and he said to them, "Listen, rebels! Are we to bring water for you
from this rock?" 11 Then Moses raised his hand and struck the rock
twice with his rod; and the water gushed out, and the congregation
drank, and their animals too. 12 But Yahweh said to Moses and Aaron,
"Because you did not believe in me, to treat me as holy in the eyes of
the Israelites, therefore you will not bring this assembly into the land
that I have given them." 13 These are the waters of Meribah,[b] where
the Israelites quarreled with Yahweh, and he showed himself holy
among them.[c]
14 Moses sent messengers from Kadesh to the king of Edom: "Thus
says your brother Israel: You know all the hardship that has come
upon us, 15 how our ancestors went down into Egypt, and we stayed in
Egypt a long time, and the Egyptians mistreated us and our ancestors.
16 And when we cried to Yahweh, he heard our voice and sent an angel[d]
and brought us out of Egypt. Now we are at Kadesh, a city on the
edge of your territory. 17 Please let us cross your land. We will not go
through any field or vineyard, and we will not drink from any well;
we will keep to the King's Highway,[e] and not veer to the right or the
left until we have crossed your territory." 18 But Edom said to him,
"You shall not pass through me, or I will come out with the sword
against you." 19 The Israelites replied, "We will keep to the main road,
and if my livestock and I drink any of your water, I will pay for it. Just
let me pass through on foot; nothing more." 20 But he answered, "You
shall not cross." And Edom marched out to meet them with a great

army and a strong hand. 21 So Edom refused to let Israel pass through
his territory, and Israel turned away from him.
22 The Israelites, the whole congregation, left Kadesh and arrived at
Mount Hor. 23 Yahweh spoke to Moses and Aaron at Mount Hor, on
the border of the land of Edom, saying, 24 "Aaron shall be gathered to
his people; he shall not enter the land that I am giving to the Israelites,
because both of you rebelled against my command at the waters of
Meribah. 25 Take Aaron and Eleazar his son and bring them up to
Mount Hor. 26 Strip Aaron of his garments and put them on Eleazar
his son. Aaron is to be gathered to his people and will die there." 27
Moses did as Yahweh commanded. They went up to Mount Hor in
the sight of the whole congregation. 28 Moses stripped Aaron of his
garments and put them on Eleazar his son, and Aaron died there on
the top of the mountain. Then Moses and Eleazar came down from
the mountain. 29 And when all the congregation saw that Aaron had
died, the whole house of Israel mourned for Aaron thirty days.[f]

Notes

- a (20:1) The first month of the spring-start religious calendar, Abib (later Nisan); the dates fall in different parts of March and April from year to year because the months were lunar. The year is not stated; it is usually taken to be the fortieth year after the exodus (compare 33:38).
- b (20:13) Meribah means "quarreling." Compare Exodus 17:7.
- c (20:13) The Hebrew verb for "he showed himself holy" (yiqqadesh) echoes the name Kadesh. At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 3:24–28, in which Moses pleads to enter the land. The Dead Sea Scroll 4QNum[b] preserves a similar expansion. See the note at 10:10.
- d (20:16) Or "a messenger."
- e (20:17) The ancient main road east of the Jordan, running north to south from Damascus to the Gulf of Aqaba.
- f (20:29) According to 33:38, Aaron died on the first day of the fifth month of the fortieth year (in July–August).

Chapter 21

1 When the Canaanite king of Arad, who lived in the Negev, heard
that Israel was coming by the Atharim road,[a] he attacked Israel and
took some of them prisoner. 2 So Israel made a vow to Yahweh, and
said, "If you will indeed deliver this people into my hand, I will utterly

destroy their cities."[b] 3 And Yahweh heard Israel's voice and delivered
up the Canaanites; and they utterly destroyed them and their cities.
So the place was named Hormah.[c]
4 Then they journeyed from Mount Hor by the Way of the Red Sea,
to go around the land of Edom; and the people grew discouraged be-
cause of the way. 5 The people spoke against God and against Moses,
"Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness?
For there is no bread and no water, and we loathe this worthless food."
6 So Yahweh sent poisonous snakes[d] among the people; they bit the
people, and a great number in Israel died. 7 The people came to Moses
and said, "We have sinned, for we have spoken against Yahweh and
against you. Pray to Yahweh, that he take away the serpents from us."
So Moses prayed for the people. 8 And Yahweh said to Moses, "Make
a fiery serpent and set it on a pole. Everyone who is bitten, when he
sees it, will live." 9 Moses made a bronze snake[e] and mounted it on a
pole; and whenever a snake bit someone, that person would look at
the bronze snake and live.
10 The Israelites set out and camped at Oboth. 11 And they journeyed
from Oboth and camped at Iye Abarim,[f] in the wilderness which is
east of Moab, toward the rising of the sun. 12 From there they set out
and camped in the Valley of Zered. 13 From there they set out and
camped beside the Arnon, which is in the wilderness stretching out
from the Amorite border; for the Arnon forms the boundary of Moab,
between Moab and the Amorites. 14 Therefore the Book of the Wars
of Yahweh[g] says: "Waheb in Suphah,[h] and the ravines of the Arnon,
15 and the slope of the ravines that reaches toward the dwelling of Ar,
and borders on Moab."
16 From there they went to Beer.[i] That is the well of which Yahweh said
to Moses, "Gather the people together, and I will give them water."
17 Then Israel sang this song: "Spring up, O well! Sing to it! 18 the
well that the chiefs dug, that the nobles of the people excavated, with
the ruler's staff and with their own staffs." And from the wilderness
they went on to Mattanah,[j] 19 and from Mattanah to Nahaliel, and
from Nahaliel to Bamoth, 20 and from Bamoth to the valley that is

in the country of Moab, by the top of Pisgah, which looks down on the wasteland.[k]

21 Then Israel sent messengers to Sihon king of the Amorites, saying,
22 "Let me cross your land. We will not turn off into any field or vineyard, and we will not drink well water; we will travel the King's Highway until we have crossed your territory." 23 But Sihon refused to let Israel cross his territory. He assembled all his people, marched out against Israel into the wilderness, reached Jahaz, and fought Israel. 24 And Israel struck him with the edge of the sword and took possession of his land from the Arnon to the Jabbok, as far as the Ammonites, for the border of the Ammonites was strong.[l] 25 Israel captured all these cities and settled in all the Amorite cities, including Heshbon and all its dependent villages.[m] 26 For Heshbon was the city of Sihon king of the Amorites, who had fought the earlier king of Moab and seized all his land from him, as far as the Arnon. 27 Therefore the ballad singers say, "Come to Heshbon, let it be built; let the city of Sihon be established. 28 For fire went out from Heshbon, flame from the city of Sihon. It consumed Ar of Moab, the lords of the heights of the Arnon.[n] 29 Woe to you, Moab! You are lost, O people of Chemosh![o] He has given up his sons as fugitives, and his daughters into captivity, to Sihon king of the Amorites. 30 But we shot them down; Heshbon has perished, as far as Dibon, and we laid waste as far as Nophah, which reaches to Medeba."[p]

31 So Israel settled in the land of the Amorites. 32 Moses sent to spy out Jazer, and they captured its villages and drove out the Amorites who were there. 33 Then they turned and went up by the way of Bashan. And Og king of Bashan came out against them, he and all his people, to battle at Edrei. 34 And Yahweh said to Moses, "Do not be afraid of him, for I have delivered him into your hand, with all his people and his land; and you shall do to him as you did to Sihon king of the Amorites, who lived at Heshbon." 35 So they struck him down, with his sons and all his people, until none was left to him alive; and they took possession of his land.

Notes

- a (21:1) Or "the way of the spies." The meaning of Atharim is uncertain.

- b (21:2) Hebrew kharam, to devote irrevocably to God, usually by destruction.
- c (21:3) Hormah means "destruction."
- d (21:6) Hebrew seraf, "burning one," probably for the burning pain of the bite. The same word describes the seraphim in Isaiah 6:2.
- e (21:9) Hebrew nekhash nekhoshet, a wordplay: "a serpent of bronze." King Hezekiah later destroyed it because it had become an object of worship (2 Kings 18:4). Compare John 3:14–15.
- f (21:11) Iye-abarim means "ruins of Abarim" or "ruins of the regions beyond." At several points in this chapter (after verses 11, 12, 20, and 21) the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 2. See the note at 10:10.
- g (21:14) A lost collection of poems about Israel's battles, known only from this quotation.
- h (21:14) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. Waheb and Suphah may be place names; the line lacks a verb, since the quotation begins mid-sentence.
- i (21:16) Beer means "well."
- j (21:18) Mattanah means "gift." Nahaliel means "valley of God." Bamoth means "heights."
- k (21:20) Or "Jeshimon."
- l (21:24) The Septuagint reads "for Jazer was the border of the Ammonites."
- m (21:25) Hebrew "daughters."
- n (21:28) Or "the high places of the Arnon."
- o (21:29) Chemosh was the national god of Moab.
- p (21:30) The meaning of verse 30 is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "fire" (Hebrew 'esh) in place of "which" ('asher), a reading many scholars prefer, giving "and fire was kindled as far as Medeba."

Chapter 22

1 Then the Israelites set out and camped in the plains of Moab beyond
the Jordan at Jericho.[a]
2 Now Balak son of Zippor[b] saw all that Israel had done to the Amor-
ites. 3 And Moab was terrified of the people, because they were so
many; Moab was sick with dread because of the Israelites. 4 And Moab
said to the elders of Midian, "This horde will now lick up everything
around us, as an ox licks up the grass of the field." Balak son of Zippor
was king of Moab at that time. 5 He sent messengers to Balaam son of
Beor[c] at Pethor, which is near the River,[d] in the land of the people of
his kin,[e] to call him, saying, "A people has come out of Egypt. They
cover the face of the earth, and they are settled opposite me. 6 Now
then, please come and lay a curse on this people for me, for they are

mightier than I; perhaps I may then defeat them and drive them out of the land; for I know that whoever you bless is blessed, and whoever you curse is cursed."
7 So the elders of Moab and the elders of Midian departed with the fees for divination in their hand. They came to Balaam and spoke to him the words of Balak. 8 He told them, "Spend the night here, and I will report back to you what Yahweh says to me." So the Moabite officials stayed with Balaam. 9 And God came to Balaam and said, "Who are these men with you?" 10 Balaam said to God, "Balak son of Zippor, king of Moab, has sent to me, saying, 11 'Look, the people who have come out of Egypt cover the face of the earth. Now come, curse them for me. Perhaps I will be able to fight against them and drive them out.'" 12 And God said to Balaam, "You shall not go with them; you shall not curse the people, for they are blessed." 13 So Balaam rose in the morning and said to the princes of Balak, "Go to your own land, for Yahweh has refused to let me go with you." 14 So the Moabite officials got up, went to Balak, and said, "Balaam refuses to come with us."
15 Once again Balak sent princes, more numerous and more honorable than these. 16 They came to Balaam and said to him, "Thus says Balak son of Zippor: 'Please let nothing hinder you from coming to me, 17 for I will reward you very handsomely and do whatever you tell me. Please come and curse this people for me.'" 18 Then Balaam answered and said to Balak's servants, "Though Balak were to give me his house full of silver and gold, I could not go beyond the word of Yahweh my God, to do less or more. 19 So now, please stay here tonight also, so that I may know what more Yahweh will say to me." 20 That night God came to Balaam and said to him, "Since the men have come to summon you, get up and go with them; but you shall do only what I tell you."
21 So Balaam rose in the morning, saddled his donkey, and went with the princes of Moab. 22 But God's anger burned because he went, and the angel of Yahweh[f] took his stand in the road as an adversary[g] against him. Now he was riding on his donkey, and his two servants were with him. 23 When the donkey saw Yahweh's angel standing in the road, his sword drawn in his hand, she veered off the road into

the field; and Balaam beat the donkey to turn her back onto the road.
24 Then Yahweh's angel stood in a narrow lane between the vineyards,
with a wall on one side and a wall on the other. 25 And the donkey
saw Yahweh's angel and pressed against the wall, crushing Balaam's
foot against it; so he beat her again. 26 Then the angel of Yahweh
went ahead and stood in a narrow place, where there was no way to
turn either to the right or to the left. 27 And when the donkey saw
Yahweh's angel, she crouched down beneath Balaam; and Balaam's
anger blazed, and he beat the donkey with his staff. 28 Then Yahweh
opened the mouth of the donkey, and she said to Balaam, "What have
I done to you, that you have struck me these three times?" 29 Balaam
said to the donkey, "Because you have mocked me! If there were a
sword in my hand, I would kill you right now." 30 And the donkey said
to Balaam, "Am I not your donkey, the one you have ridden all your
life long until today? Was I ever in the habit of doing this to you?"
And he said, "No."
31 Then Yahweh uncovered Balaam's eyes, and he saw Yahweh's angel
standing in the road with his sword drawn in his hand; and he bowed
his head and fell flat on his face. 32 The angel of Yahweh said to him,
"Why have you struck your donkey these three times? Look, I have
come out as an adversary, because your way is reckless[h] before me. 33
The donkey saw me and turned aside before me these three times. If
she had not turned aside from me, surely by now I would have killed
you and let her live." 34 And Balaam said to Yahweh's angel, "I have
sinned, for I did not know you were standing in the road to oppose
me. Now, if it displeases you, I will go back." 35 But Yahweh's angel
said to Balaam, "Go with the men; yet only the word I will speak to
you shall you speak." So Balaam went with Balak's officials.
36 When Balak heard that Balaam was coming, he went out to meet
him at Ir-moab,[i] on the border formed by the Arnon, at the edge of
the territory. 37 Balak said to Balaam, "Did I not send to you urgently
to call you? Why did you not come to me? Am I not able to honor
you?" 38 And Balaam said to Balak, "Here I am; I have come to you. But
can I really speak just anything? The word God puts in my mouth is
the only one I can speak." 39 Then Balaam went with Balak, and they

came to Kiriath-huzoth.[j] 40 And Balak sacrificed oxen and sheep and sent some to Balaam and to the princes who were with him.
41 In the morning Balak took Balaam and brought him up to Bamoth-baal,[k] and from there he saw the edge of the people.

Notes

- a (22:1) Hebrew "beyond the Jordan of Jericho," that is, on the east side of the Jordan, opposite Jericho.
- b (22:2) Balak perhaps means "devastator." Zippor means "bird."
- c (22:5) Balaam perhaps means "devourer" or "the clan brings forth." Beor means "burning." A plastered wall inscription from about 800 BC found at Deir ʻAlla in Jordan tells of a seer named "Balaam son of Beor" who received a vision from the gods at night.
- d (22:5) That is, the Euphrates.
- e (22:5) Or "in the land of the Amawites," a people known from ancient inscriptions. The Samaritan Pentateuch, the Syriac, and the Vulgate read "the land of the Ammonites."
- f (22:22) Or "the messenger of Yahweh," a heavenly being who speaks and acts for Yahweh, at times as Yahweh himself. So throughout this chapter. Compare Exodus 3:2.
- g (22:22) Hebrew satan, "adversary" or "opponent." So also in verse 32.
- h (22:32) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; perhaps "perverse" or "headlong."
- i (22:36) Or "the city of Moab."
- j (22:39) Kiriath-huzoth means "city of streets."
- k (22:41) Bamoth-baal means "high places of Baal."

Chapter 23

1 Then Balaam said to Balak, "Build seven altars for me here, and prepare seven bulls and seven rams for me here." 2 Balak did as Balaam had said. Balak and Balaam offered a bull and a ram on each altar. 3 Then Balaam said to Balak, "Stay by your burnt offering, and I will go; perhaps Yahweh will come to meet me, and whatever he reveals to me I will tell you." So he went up to a barren hilltop.[a] 4 Then God met Balaam, and he said to him, "I have set up seven altars, and on each altar I have offered a bull and a ram." 5 And Yahweh put a word in Balaam's mouth and said, "Return to Balak, and this is what you are to say." 6 So he returned to him, and there he was, standing beside his burnt offering, he and all the princes of Moab.

7 And he took up his poem[b] and said: “From Aram Balak brought me,
Moab’s king from the eastern mountains: ‘Come, put a curse on Jacob
for me; come, denounce Israel!’ 8 How can I curse whom God has not
cursed? How can I denounce whom Yahweh has not denounced? 9
For from the rocky peaks I see them, and from the hills I watch them;
behold, a people who live alone and do not reckon themselves among
the nations! 10 Who can count the dust of Jacob, or number the fourth
part[c] of Israel? Let me die the death of the upright, and let my end be
like his!”
11 Then Balak said to Balaam, “What have you done to me? I brought
you to curse my enemies, but you have only blessed them!” 12 He
answered and said, “Must I not take care to speak what Yahweh puts
in my mouth?”
13 Balak said to him, “Please come with me to another place, from
which you may see them. You will see only the edge of them and will
not see them all. Curse them for me from there.” 14 So he took him to
the field of Zophim,[d] to the top of Pisgah, and built seven altars and
offered a bull and a ram on each altar. 15 So he said to Balak, “Stay here
by your burnt offering while I go and meet Yahweh over there.” 16 And
Yahweh met Balaam and put a word in his mouth and said, “Return
to Balak, and this is what you are to say.” 17 So he came to him, and
there he was, standing beside his burnt offering, and the princes of
Moab with him. And Balak said to him, “What has Yahweh spoken?”
18 And he took up his poem and said: “Get up, Balak, and listen; hear
me out, son of Zippor: 19 God is not a human being, that he should
lie, nor a mortal, that he should change his mind. Has he spoken, and
will he not do it? Or has he promised, and will he not make it good? 20
Look, I have received a command to bless; he has blessed, and I cannot
revoke it. 21 No misfortune is seen in Jacob, nor trouble observed in
Israel.[e] Yahweh their God is with them, and the acclaim of a king is
in their midst. 22 God brings them out of Egypt; he is like the horns
of the wild ox[f] for them. 23 For there is no spell against Jacob, and no
divination against Israel;[g] at the proper time it will be said to Jacob
and to Israel, ‘Look at what God has done!’ 24 Behold, a people that

rises like a lioness and lifts itself like a lion; it does not lie down till it devours its prey and drinks the blood of the slain."
25 Then Balak said to Balaam, "Neither curse them at all, nor bless them at all!" 26 But Balaam answered Balak, "Did I not tell you, 'All that Yahweh speaks, that I must do'?"
27 And Balak said to Balaam, "Come now, let me take you to another place; perhaps it will please God to let you curse them for me from there." 28 So Balak took Balaam to the top of Peor, which overlooks the wasteland. 29 Then Balaam said to Balak, "Build seven altars for me here, and prepare seven bulls and seven rams for me here." 30 And Balak did as Balaam had said, and offered a bull and a ram on each altar.

Notes

- a (23:3) The meaning of the Hebrew word shefi is uncertain; it may mean a bare hill or "alone."
- b (23:7) Hebrew mashal, a word used for proverbs, parables, taunts, and oracles. So also in verse 18 and in chapter 24.
- c (23:10) Or "the dust clouds." The Hebrew word rova' is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "the families"; some ancient versions read "the multitudes."
- d (23:14) Zophim means "watchers" or "lookouts."
- e (23:21) Or "No one has seen iniquity in Jacob, or mischief in Israel."
- f (23:22) Or "the strength of a wild ox." The meaning of the Hebrew to'afot is uncertain.
- g (23:23) Or "in Jacob ... in Israel," meaning that Israel does not practice divination.

Chapter 24

1 Now when Balaam saw that it was good in Yahweh's eyes to bless Israel, he did not go as he had done before to seek omens, but turned his face toward the wilderness. 2 And Balaam raised his eyes and saw Israel encamped by tribes; and the Spirit of God came upon him. 3 Then he took up his poem and said: "The declaration of Balaam the son of Beor, the declaration of the man whose eyes are open,[a] 4 the oracle of him who hears the words of God, who sees the vision of the Almighty,[b] falling down, with his eyes uncovered: 5 How beautiful are your tents, O Jacob, your dwellings, O Israel! 6 Like valleys that stretch out, like gardens beside a river, like aloes that Yahweh has planted, like cedar trees beside the waters. 7 Water shall flow from his

buckets, and his seed shall be by plentiful water.[c] His king shall be greater than Agag,[d] and his kingdom shall be exalted. 8 God brings him out of Egypt; he is like the horns of the wild ox for him. He will devour the nations, his adversaries, and break their bones in pieces and pierce them through with his arrows. 9 He crouches, he lies down like a lion, like a lioness—who dares rouse him? Blessed be those who bless you, and cursed be those who curse you."

10 Then Balak's anger blazed against Balaam, and he clapped his hands together. And Balak said to Balaam, "I summoned you to curse my enemies, yet now you have blessed them these three times. 11 So now flee to your own place. I said that I would surely honor you, but Yahweh has kept you back from honor." 12 And Balaam said to Balak, "Did I not also tell the messengers you sent to me, 13 'Even if Balak were to give me his house full of silver and gold, I could not go beyond the command of Yahweh, to do either good or bad of my own will. What Yahweh speaks, that I will speak'? 14 Now, see, I am going back to my people. Come, and I will warn you what this people will do to your people in days to come."

15 Then he took up his poem and said: "The declaration of Balaam the son of Beor, the declaration of the man whose eyes are open, 16 the declaration of him who hears the words of God, who has knowledge from the Most High,[e] who sees a vision from the Almighty, fallen prostrate, yet with eyes unveiled: 17 I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not nearby: a star shall step forth from Jacob, and a scepter[f] shall rise from Israel; it shall smash the brow[g] of Moab, and demolish all the sons of Sheth.[h] 18 Edom will be a possession; Seir also, his enemies, will be a possession, while Israel does valiantly. 19 One from Jacob will exercise dominion and destroy the survivors of the city."

20 Then he looked toward Amalek and took up his poem and said: "Amalek was first of the nations, but its end is to perish forever."

21 Then he looked toward the Kenites and took up his poem and said: "Secure is your dwelling, and in the cliff your nest is set;[i] 22 Nevertheless, Kain will be burned when Asshur takes you away captive."[j]

23 And he took up his discourse and said, “Alas, who will live when
God does this?[k] 24 But ships shall come from the coast of Kittim[l] and
humble Asshur and Eber; and he too shall perish forever.”
25 Then Balaam got up and returned to his own place; and Balak
likewise went on his way.

Notes

- a (24:3) Or “closed.” The meaning of the Hebrew shetum is uncertain. So also in verse 15.
- b (24:4) Hebrew Shaddai, a name of God of uncertain meaning, traditionally rendered “the Almighty.” So also in verse 16.
- c (24:7) The meaning of the line is uncertain. The Septuagint reads, “A man will come out of his seed, and he will rule over many nations.”
- d (24:7) Agag was a king of the Amalekites; compare 1 Samuel 15:8. The Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read “Gog.”
- e (24:16) Hebrew ‘Elyon.
- f (24:17) Hebrew shevet, “scepter” or “tribe.” The Septuagint reads “a man.” The verse was read messianically in later Jewish and Christian tradition; the Dead Sea Scrolls cite it (for example, in the Damascus Document and 4QTestimonia), and the second-century leader Simeon bar Kosiba was called Bar Kokhba, “son of the star.”
- g (24:17) Or “the borders.” Hebrew “the two sides of the head.”
- h (24:17) Or “the sons of tumult.” Compare Jeremiah 48:45. Sheth may be a people’s name.
- i (24:21) Hebrew qen, “nest,” is a wordplay on Qayin, “Kain,” the name of the Kenites’ ancestor in verse 22.
- j (24:22) The meaning of verses 21–22 is uncertain. Asshur is Assyria, or possibly a tribe of that name (Genesis 25:3).
- k (24:23) The Hebrew of verses 23–24 is very difficult. The Septuagint introduces this saying with “And he looked on Og.” Some scholars, revising the Hebrew, read “Who will live among the islands of the north?”
- l (24:24) Kittim is Cyprus, and by extension the peoples of the western Mediterranean coasts.

Chapter 25

1 While Israel was staying at Shittim,[a] the people began to commit
sexual immorality with the women of Moab. 2 They invited the people
to the sacrifices of their gods, and the people ate and bowed down to
their gods. 3 So Israel attached itself to Baal of Peor;[b] and Yahweh’s
anger was kindled against Israel. 4 Yahweh said to Moses, “Take all
the chiefs of the people and impale[c] them before Yahweh in the sun,

so that the fierce anger of Yahweh may turn away from Israel." [5] So Moses said to Israel's judges, "Every one of you must kill those of his men who have attached themselves to Baal of Peor."
[6] Just then an Israelite man came and brought a Midianite woman to his relatives, before the eyes of Moses and the whole congregation of the Israelites, as they were weeping at the door of the tent of meeting. [7] When Phinehas[d] son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the priest, saw it, he rose from the midst of the congregation and took a spear in his hand. [8] and he followed the Israelite man into the tent[e] and drove the spear through both of them, the Israelite and the woman, into her belly. So the plague on the Israelites was halted. [9] Those who died in the plague were twenty-four thousand.
[10] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [11] "Phinehas the son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest, has turned my anger away from the Israelites, because he was as zealous as I am among them, so that in my zeal I did not wipe out the Israelites. [12] Therefore say, 'Look, I am giving him my covenant of peace. [13] It shall belong to him and to his offspring after him, a covenant of lasting priesthood, because he was jealous for his God's honor and made atonement for the Israelites.'"
[14] Now the name of the Israelite who was slain with the Midianite woman was Zimri the son of Salu, chief of an ancestral house among the Simeonites. [15] And the name of the Midianite woman who was slain was Cozbi the daughter of Zur; he was the head of a tribal clan in Midian.[f]
[16] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [17] "Harass the Midianites and strike them down, [18] for they have troubled you with their trickery, with which they led you astray in the matter of Peor and of Cozbi, daughter of a Midianite chief, their sister, who was killed on the day of the plague over Peor."[g]

Notes

- a (25:1) Shittim means "acacia trees."
- b (25:3) Baal means "lord" or "master," the title of a Canaanite storm god. Baal of Peor was the god worshiped at Peor (compare 23:28).
- c (25:4) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; it may mean to impale, to hang, or to expose with broken limbs. The Septuagint reads "make an example of them."

- d (25:7) Phinehas is an Egyptian name meaning “the Nubian.”
- e (25:8) The Hebrew word qubbah, found only here, probably refers to a tent shrine or an inner chamber.
- f (25:15) Zimri means “my protection” or “my song.” Salu is of uncertain meaning. Cozbi perhaps means “deceitful” or “voluptuous.” Zur means “rock.”
- g (25:18) In the Hebrew text, the sentence “After the plague” forms verse 19 of chapter 25. In English Bibles it begins 26:1.

Chapter 26

1 After the plague, Yahweh spoke to Moses and to Eleazar son of
Aaron the priest, saying, 2 “Take a census of the entire congregation
of the Israelites, twenty years old and up, by their ancestral houses,
all in Israel who can serve in the army.” 3 So Moses and Eleazar
the priest spoke with them in the plains of Moab by the Jordan at
Jericho, saying, 4 “Take a census of the people from twenty years old
and upward,” as Yahweh had commanded Moses.[a] These were the
Israelites who came out of the land of Egypt:
5 Reuben, the firstborn of Israel. The descendants of Reuben: Hanoch,
the clan of the Hanochites; Pallu, the clan of the Palluites; 6 Hezron,
the clan of the Hezronites; Carmi, the clan of the Carmites. 7 These
were the clans of the Reubenites, and those counted of them were
43,730. 8 The son of Pallu was Eliab. 9 The sons of Eliab: Nemuel,
Dathan, and Abiram. This is the Dathan and Abiram, summoned from
the congregation, who defied Moses and Aaron in Korah’s faction
when they defied Yahweh, 10 and the earth opened its mouth and
swallowed them up together with Korah, when that company died,
when the fire consumed two hundred fifty men, and they became a
warning. 11 But the sons of Korah did not die.
12 The descendants of Simeon by their clans: Nemuel, the clan of the
Nemuelites; Jamin, the clan of the Jaminites; Jachin, the clan of the
Jachinites; 13 Zerah, the clan of the Zerahites; Shaul, the clan of the
Shaulites. 14 These were the clans of the Simeonites, 22,200.
15 The descendants of Gad by their clans: Zephon, the clan of the
Zephonites; Haggi, the clan of the Haggites; Shuni, the clan of the
Shunites; 16 Ozni, the clan of the Oznites; Eri, the clan of the Erites; 17
Arod, the clan of the Arodites; Areli, the clan of the Arelites. 18 These

were the clans of the descendants of Gad, according to those counted of them, 40,500.
19 The sons of Judah were Er and Onan, and Er and Onan died in the land of Canaan. 20 The descendants of Judah by their clans were: Shelah, the clan of the Shelanites; Perez, the clan of the Perezites; Zerah, the clan of the Zerahites. 21 The descendants of Perez were: Hezron, the clan of the Hezronites; Hamul, the clan of the Hamulites. 22 These were the clans of Judah, according to those counted of them, 76,500.
23 The descendants of Issachar by their clans: Tola, the clan of the Tolaites; Puvah, the clan of the Punites; 24 Jashub, the clan of the Jashubites; Shimron, the clan of the Shimronites. 25 These were the clans of Issachar, according to those counted of them, 64,300.
26 The descendants of Zebulun by their clans: Sered, the clan of the Seredites; Elon, the clan of the Elonites; Jahleel, the clan of the Jahleelites. 27 These were the clans of the Zebulunites, according to those counted of them, 60,500.
28 The descendants of Joseph by their clans: Manasseh and Ephraim. 29 The descendants of Manasseh: Machir, the clan of the Machirites; and Machir fathered Gilead; Gilead, the clan of the Gileadites. 30 These were the descendants of Gilead: Iezer,[b] the clan of the Iezerites; Helek, the clan of the Helekites; 31 Asriel, the clan of the Asrielites; Shechem, the clan of the Shechemites; 32 Shemida, the clan of the Shemidaites; Hepher, the clan of the Hepherites. 33 Zelophehad son of Hepher had no sons, but only daughters. The names of the daughters of Zelophehad were Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah.[c] 34 These were the clans of Manasseh, and those counted of them were 52,700.
35 These were the descendants of Ephraim by their clans: Shuthelah, the clan of the Shuthelahites; Becher, the clan of the Becherites; Tahan, the clan of the Tahanites. 36 And these were the descendants of Shuthelah: Eran, the clan of the Eranites. 37 These were the clans of the descendants of Ephraim, according to those counted of them, 32,500. These were the descendants of Joseph by their clans.
38 The descendants of Benjamin by their clans: Bela, the clan of the Belaites; Ashbel, the clan of the Ashbelites; Ahiram, the clan of the

Ahiramites; [39] Shephupham,[d] the clan of the Shuphamites; Hupham, the clan of the Huphamites. [40] The sons of Bela were Ard and Naaman: Ard, the clan of the Ardites; Naaman, the clan of the Naamites. [41] These were the descendants of Benjamin by their clans, and those counted of them were 45,600.

[42] These are the sons of Dan according to their families: through Shuham, the Shuhamite family. These were the families of Dan, family by family. [43] All the clans of the Shuhamites, according to those counted of them, were 64,400.

[44] The descendants of Asher by their clans: Imnah, the clan of the Imnites; Ishvi, the clan of the Ishvites; Beriah, the clan of the Beriites. [45] Of the descendants of Beriah: Heber, the clan of the Heberites; Malchiel, the clan of the Malchielites. [46] And the name of the daughter of Asher was Serah. [47] These were the clans of the descendants of Asher, according to those counted of them, 53,400.

[48] The descendants of Naphtali by their clans: Jahzeel, the clan of the Jahzeelites; Guni, the clan of the Gunites; [49] Jezer, the clan of the Jezerites; Shillem, the clan of the Shillemites. [50] These were the clans of Naphtali by their clans, and those counted of them were 45,400.

[51] These were those counted of the Israelites, 601,730.[e]

[52] Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, [53] "Among these the land is to be divided as an inheritance according to the number of names. [54] To a large tribe you are to give a larger inheritance, and to a small tribe you are to give a smaller inheritance. Each is to be given its inheritance in proportion to those counted of it. [55] But the land is to be divided by lot. They are to inherit according to the names of the tribes of their fathers. [56] Their inheritance is to be divided by lot between the larger and the smaller."

[57] These were those counted of the Levites by their clans: Gershon, the clan of the Gershonites; Kohath, the clan of the Kohathites; Merari, the clan of the Merarites. [58] These were the families of Levi: Libni's family, Hebron's family, Mahli's family, Mushi's family, Korah's family. And Kohath was the father of Amram. [59] The name of Amram's wife was Jochebed the daughter of Levi, who was born to Levi in Egypt; and to Amram she bore Aaron, Moses, and their sister Miriam.

60 To Aaron were born Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar. 61 But Nadab and Abihu died when they offered unauthorized fire before Yahweh. 62 Those counted among them numbered 23,000, every male a month old and up; for they were not counted among the Israelites, because no inheritance was assigned to them among the Israelites.
63 These were those counted by Moses and Eleazar the priest, who counted the Israelites in the plains of Moab by the Jordan at Jericho. 64 But among these there was not a man of those counted by Moses and Aaron the priest, who had counted the Israelites in the Wilderness of Sinai. 65 For Yahweh had said of them, "They will surely die in the wilderness." Not one of them was left, except Caleb son of Jephunneh and Joshua son of Nun.

Notes

- a (26:4) The words "Take a census of the people" are not in the Hebrew, which is abrupt here; they are supplied from verse 2.
- b (26:30) In Joshua 17:2 the name is Abiezer.
- c (26:33) Mahlah perhaps means "weakness"; Noah (not the same name as Noah of the flood), "movement"; Hoglah, "partridge"; Milcah, "queen"; Tirzah, "pleasing."
- d (26:39) So the traditional Hebrew text. Some manuscripts and ancient versions read "Shupham" (compare the clan name); Genesis 46:21 has Muppim.
- e (26:51) The total is slightly less than the 603,550 of the first census (1:46). On the meaning of the figures, see the note at 1:46.

Chapter 27

1 Then the daughters of Zelophehad the son of Hepher, son of Gilead, son of Machir, son of Manasseh, of the families of Manasseh the son of Joseph, came near. The names of his daughters were Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah. 2 They stood before Moses, before Eleazar the priest, before the leaders, and before the whole congregation at the entrance of the tent of meeting, and said, 3 "Our father died in the wilderness; he was not among those who gathered against Yahweh in Korah's faction, but he died for his own sin, and had no sons. 4 Why should our father's name disappear from among his family because he had no son? Give us a possession among our father's relatives."
5 Moses brought their case before Yahweh.[a] 6 And Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 7 "The daughters of Zelophehad speak rightly; you

shall certainly give them a possession of inheritance among their father's relatives, and cause the inheritance of their father to pass to them. 8 And you are to speak to the Israelites, saying, 'If a man dies and has no son, then you are to transfer his inheritance to his daughter. 9 And if he has no daughter, then you shall give his inheritance to his brothers. 10 And if he has no brothers, then you shall give his inheritance to his father's brothers. 11 And if his father has no brothers, then you shall give his inheritance to the relative nearest to him in his family, and he shall possess it. And it shall be a legal requirement for the Israelites, as Yahweh commanded Moses.'"
12 Yahweh said to Moses, "Go up into this mountain of Abarim[b] and see the land that I have given to the Israelites. 13 And when you have seen it, you also shall be gathered to your people, just as your brother Aaron was gathered, 14 for in the Wilderness of Zin, when the congregation quarreled, you both rebelled against my word to honor me as holy before their eyes at the water." (That is the water of Meribah at Kadesh in the Wilderness of Zin.)
15 Moses spoke to Yahweh, saying, 16 "Let Yahweh, the God of the spirits of all flesh, appoint a man over the congregation, 17 who will lead them out and lead them in, going before them and coming before them, that Yahweh's congregation may not be as sheep with no shepherd." 18 So Yahweh said to Moses, "Take Joshua son of Nun, a man in whom is the Spirit,[c] and lay your hand on him. 19 Have him stand before Eleazar the priest and before the whole congregation, and commission him in their sight. 20 You are to put some of your authority on him, so that the whole congregation of the Israelites may obey. 21 He shall stand before Eleazar the priest, who shall seek counsel for him by the decision of the Urim[d] before Yahweh; at his word they shall go out and at his word they shall come in, he and all the Israelites with him, the entire congregation." 22 Moses did as Yahweh commanded him. He took Joshua and had him stand before Eleazar the priest and before the whole congregation, 23 and he laid his hands on him and commissioned him, as Yahweh had directed through Moses.[e]

Notes

- a (27:5) In the traditional Hebrew text the final letter of "their case" (mishpatan) is written larger than normal.
- b (27:12) Abarim means "regions beyond," the mountain range east of the Dead Sea that includes Mount Nebo (Deuteronomy 32:49).
- c (27:18) Or "spirit."
- d (27:21) The Urim and Thummim were objects kept in the high priest's breastpiece and used to learn God's will (Exodus 28:30). The meaning of the words is uncertain; Urim may be related to 'or, "light."
- e (27:23) At this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds material drawn from Deuteronomy 3:21–22, in which Moses encourages Joshua. The Dead Sea Scroll 4QNum[b] preserves a similar expansion. See the note at 10:10.

Chapter 28

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Command the Israelites and say
to them, 'You are to take care to present to me at its appointed time
my offering, my food for my offerings by fire, a pleasing aroma to
me.' 3 And you are to say to them, 'This is the offering by fire that you
are to present to Yahweh: male lambs a year old without blemish, two
each day, as a regular burnt offering. 4 You are to offer the one lamb
in the morning, and the other lamb you are to offer at twilight,[a] 5 with
about 2 quarts of fine flour for a grain offering, mixed with about 1
quart of oil from pressed olives.[b] 6 It is a regular burnt offering, which
was instituted at Mount Sinai as a pleasing aroma, an offering by fire
to Yahweh. 7 Its drink offering shall be about 1 quart for each lamb; in
the sanctuary you shall pour out strong drink[c] as a drink offering to
Yahweh. 8 The other lamb you are to offer at twilight. Like the grain
offering of the morning and its drink offering, you are to offer it as
an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh.
9 "'On the Sabbath day: two male lambs a year old without blemish,
and about 4 quarts of fine flour[d] for a grain offering, mixed with oil,
and its drink offering. 10 This is the burnt offering for each Sabbath,
in addition to the continual burnt offering and its drink offering.
11 "'At the beginnings of your months[e] you are to present a burnt
offering to Yahweh: two young bulls, one ram, and seven male lambs
a year old without blemish; 12 also about 6 quarts of fine flour for a
grain offering, mixed with oil, for each bull; and about 4 quarts of
fine flour for a grain offering, mixed with oil, for the one ram; 13 and

about 2 quarts of fine flour mixed with oil as a grain offering for each lamb,[f] for a burnt offering of pleasing aroma, an offering by fire to Yahweh. 14 Their drink offerings are to be about 2 quarts of wine for a bull, about 1⅓ quarts for a ram, and about 1 quart for a lamb.[g] This is the burnt offering of each month throughout the months of the year. 15 Also one male goat for a sin offering to Yahweh is to be offered, besides the regular burnt offering and its drink offering.

16 "'On the fourteenth day of the first month (in March–April)[h] is Yahweh's Passover. 17 And on the fifteenth day of this month is a festival. For seven days unleavened bread is to be eaten. 18 On the first day there is to be a holy assembly. You must not do any ordinary work. 19 You shall present a fire offering, a burnt offering to Yahweh: two young bulls, one ram, and seven yearling male lambs; see that they are perfect. 20 Their grain offering shall be fine flour mingled with oil: about 6 quarts for a bull and about 4 quarts for the ram; 21 about 2 quarts you are to offer for each of the seven lambs; 22 also one male goat for a sin offering, to make atonement for you. 23 You are to offer these besides the burnt offering of the morning, which is for a regular burnt offering. 24 In this way you are to offer daily, for seven days, the food of the offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh. It is to be offered besides the regular burnt offering and its drink offering. 25 And on the seventh day you are to have a holy assembly. You must not do any ordinary work.

26 "'On the day of the firstfruits,[i] when you present a new grain offering to Yahweh at your Festival of Weeks, you are to have a holy assembly. You must not do any ordinary work. 27 You are to present a burnt offering as a pleasing aroma to Yahweh: two young bulls, one ram, and seven male lambs a year old; 28 also their grain offering of fine flour mixed with oil, about 6 quarts for each bull, about 4 quarts for the one ram, 29 and about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs; 30 also one male goat, to make atonement for you. 31 Besides the regular burnt offering and its grain offering, you are to offer them and their drink offerings. See that they are without blemish.'"

Notes

- a (28:4) Hebrew "between the two evenings," probably the time between sunset and dark. So also in verse 8. See the note at Exodus 12:6.
- b (28:5) Hebrew "a tenth of an ephah of fine flour … a quarter of a hin of beaten oil," about 2.2 liters of flour and 0.9 liter of oil. An ephah was about three-fifths of a bushel (22 liters), and a hin about 1 gallon (3.7 liters); standards varied. So also with the drink offering in verse 7.
- c (28:7) Hebrew shekar, a fermented drink, possibly beer.
- d (28:9) Hebrew "two-tenths," about 4.4 liters.
- e (28:11) Hebrew "heads of your months," the new moon at the beginning of each lunar month.
- f (28:13) Hebrew "three-tenths … two-tenths … a tenth" of an ephah, about 6.6, 4.4, and 2.2 liters. The same amounts are given in verses 20–21, 28–29, and in chapter 29.
- g (28:14) Hebrew "half a hin … a third of a hin … a quarter of a hin," about 1.9, 1.2, and 0.9 liters.
- h (28:16) First month: Abib, later called Nisan, of the spring-start religious calendar. Because the months were lunar, the dates fall in different parts of March and April from year to year.
- i (28:26) The Festival of Weeks (Shavuot) was held fifty days after the offering of the first sheaf (Leviticus 23:15–16), in the third month, Sivan (in May–June).

Chapter 29

1 "On the first day of the seventh month (in September–October)[a] you
shall hold a holy gathering; you shall do no ordinary work. It is a
day of trumpet blasts for you.[b] 2 You are to offer a burnt offering as a
pleasing aroma to Yahweh: one young bull, one ram, and seven male
lambs a year old without blemish; 3 also their grain offering of fine
flour mixed with oil, about 6 quarts for the bull, about 4 quarts for the
ram, 4 and about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs; 5 with one male
goat for a sin offering, to make atonement for you; 6 besides the new
moon burnt offering with its grain offering, and the continual burnt
offering with its grain offering, and their drink offerings as prescribed
for them—a pleasing aroma, a fire offering to Yahweh.
7 "'On the tenth day of this seventh month (in September–October)[c]
you are to have a holy assembly, and you are to humble yourselves.[d]
You must not do any work. 8 You shall present a burnt offering to
Yahweh as a pleasing aroma: one young bull, one ram, and seven
yearling male lambs; see that they are perfect. 9 Their grain offering

shall be fine flour mingled with oil, about 6 quarts for the bull, about
4 quarts for the one ram, [10] and about 2 quarts for each of the seven
lambs; [11] also one male goat for a sin offering, besides the sin offering
of atonement, and the regular burnt offering and its grain offering,
and their drink offerings.
[12] "'On the fifteenth day of the seventh month (in September–Octo-
ber)[e] you are to have a holy assembly. You must not do any ordinary
work, and you are to celebrate a festival to Yahweh seven days. [13] You
are to present a burnt offering, an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma
to Yahweh: thirteen young bulls, two rams, and fourteen male lambs
a year old. They are to be without blemish. [14] Their grain offering
shall be fine flour mingled with oil, about 6 quarts for each of the
thirteen bulls, about 4 quarts for each of the two rams, [15] and about 2
quarts for each of the fourteen lambs; [16] also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.
[17] "'On the second day: twelve young bulls, two rams, and fourteen
male lambs a year old without blemish, [18] with their grain offering
and their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; [19] also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offerings.[f]
[20] "'On the third day: eleven young bulls, two rams, and fourteen male
lambs a year old without blemish, [21] with their grain offering and
their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; [22] also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.
[23] "'On the fourth day: ten young bulls, two rams, and fourteen male
lambs a year old without blemish, [24] with their grain offering and
their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; [25] also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.

26 “‘On the fifth day: nine young bulls, two rams, and fourteen male
lambs a year old without blemish, 27 with their grain offering and
their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; 28 also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.
29 “‘On the sixth day: eight young bulls, two rams, and fourteen male
lambs a year old without blemish, 30 with their grain offering and
their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; 31 also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.
32 “‘On the seventh day: seven young bulls, two rams, and fourteen
male lambs a year old without blemish, 33 with their grain offering
and their drink offerings for the bulls, for the rams, and for the lambs,
according to their number, by the rule; 34 also one male goat for a sin
offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering, and its
drink offering.
35 “‘On the eighth day you are to have a solemn assembly.[g] You must
not do any ordinary work. 36 You are to present a burnt offering,
an offering by fire, a pleasing aroma to Yahweh: one bull, one ram,
and seven male lambs a year old without blemish, 37 with their grain
offering and their drink offerings for the bull, for the ram, and for the
lambs, according to their number, by the rule; 38 also one male goat
for a sin offering, besides the regular burnt offering, its grain offering,
and its drink offering.
39 “‘These you are to offer to Yahweh at your appointed festivals,
in addition to your vowed offerings and your freewill offerings, for
your burnt offerings, your grain offerings, your drink offerings, and
your peace offerings.’” 40 So Moses told the Israelites everything that
Yahweh had commanded Moses.[h]

Notes

- a (29:1) Seventh month: Tishri, also called Ethanim (1 Kings 8:2), of the spring-start religious calendar. Because the months were lunar, the dates fall in different

parts of September and October from year to year. In later Jewish tradition this day became Rosh Hashanah, the civil New Year.

- b (29:1) Hebrew teruʿah, a day of loud blasts, probably on the ram's horn. Compare Leviticus 23:24.
- c (29:7) The Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur). See Leviticus 16:29–34; 23:26–32.
- d (29:7) Or "afflict yourselves," traditionally understood as fasting.
- e (29:12) The Festival of Booths (Sukkot). See Leviticus 23:33–43.
- f (29:19) In verses 19, 31, and 33 the Hebrew has small irregularities of spelling ("their drink offerings," "its drink offerings," "by their rule"). Ancient rabbis noticed that the extra letters spell mayim, "water," and took this as a hint of the water libation at the Festival of Booths.
- g (29:35) Hebrew ʿatseret, a closing assembly.
- h (29:40) In the Hebrew text, verse 40 is numbered 30:1.

Chapter 30

1 Moses spoke to the heads of the tribes of the Israelites and said:
"This is what Yahweh has commanded.[a] 2 When a man makes a vow
to Yahweh, or swears an oath to bind himself by a pledge, he must
not break his word. He must do according to all that comes out of
his mouth.

3 "When a woman makes a vow to Yahweh and binds herself by a
pledge, while she is in her father's house in her youth, 4 and her father
hears about her vow, or about a pledge she has laid upon herself, and
keeps silent about it, every vow of hers is valid, and every pledge she
laid upon herself is valid. 5 But if her father forbids her on the day he
hears it, then none of her vows or pledges by which she has bound
herself shall stand; and Yahweh will release her, because her father
forbade her.

6 "And if she marries a husband while her vows are on her, or a rash
word from her lips by which she has bound herself, 7 and her husband
hears of it and says nothing on the day he hears, then her vows are
valid, and the pledges she bound upon herself are valid. 8 But if her
husband disallows it on the day he hears, he cancels the vow she is
under and the rash word from her lips with which she bound herself;
and Yahweh will release her. 9 (As for the vow of a widow or a divorced
woman, whatever she has bound upon herself is binding on her.)

10 "If she vowed in her husband's house or bound herself by a pledge
with an oath, 11 and her husband heard about it yet kept silent and
did not disallow it, then each of her vows is valid, and each pledge
she laid upon herself is valid. 12 But if her husband makes them void
on the day that he hears them, then whatever comes out of her lips
concerning her vows or concerning her pledge will not stand. Her
husband has made them void, and Yahweh will forgive her. 13 Any vow
and any binding oath to humble herself,[b] her husband may confirm,
or her husband may make void. 14 But if her husband remains silent
toward her from day to day, then he confirms all her vows and all
her pledges that are on her; he confirms them, because he remained
silent toward her on the day he heard of them. 15 But if he makes them
void after he has heard of them, then he will bear her iniquity."
16 These are the statutes that Yahweh commanded Moses regarding
a husband and his wife, and a father and his daughter in her youth,
while she is in her father's house.

Notes

- a (30:1) In the Hebrew text, verses 1–16 are numbered 30:2–17.
- b (30:13) Or "to afflict herself," perhaps by fasting.

Chapter 31

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Avenge the Israelites on the
Midianites; after that you shall be gathered to your people." 3 So Moses
spoke to the people, saying, "Arm men from among you for the war,
so that they may go against Midian to execute Yahweh's vengeance
on Midian. 4 You are to send a thousand from each tribe of all the tribes
of Israel to the war." 5 So there were supplied from the clans of Israel
a thousand from each tribe, twelve thousand armed for war.[a] 6 Moses
sent them to the war, a thousand from every tribe, and with them he
sent Phinehas, son of Eleazar the priest, who had in his hand the holy
vessels and the trumpets for sounding the alarm. 7 They waged war
against Midian, as Yahweh had commanded Moses, and killed every
male. 8 They killed the kings of Midian in addition to the others who
were slain: Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba, the five kings of Midian.[b]
They also killed Balaam the son of Beor with the sword. 9 And the

Israelites took the Midianite women and their children captive, and seized all their herds, their flocks, and all their goods as spoil. 10 They burned all the cities where they had settled, and all their camps,[c] with fire. 11 They took all the spoil and all the booty, both of humans and of animals. 12 And they brought the prisoners, along with the booty and the spoil, to Moses, Eleazar the priest, and the Israelite congregation, at the camp on the plains of Moab by the Jordan opposite Jericho.
13 Moses and Eleazar the priest and all the leaders of the congregation went out to meet them outside the camp. 14 And Moses was angry with the officers of the army, the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds, who had come from the campaign of the war. 15 Moses said to them, "Have you let all the women live? 16 Look, these were the ones who, on Balaam's advice, caused the Israelites to act unfaithfully against Yahweh in the matter of Peor, so that the plague came on the congregation of Yahweh. 17 Now therefore, kill every boy among the children, and kill every woman who has had intercourse with a man. 18 But all the young girls who have not known a man by lying with a male, keep alive for yourselves. 19 As for you, camp outside the camp seven days. Whoever has killed a person and whoever has touched a slain person, purify yourselves on the third day and on the seventh day, you and your captives. 20 You shall purify every garment, everything made of leather, everything woven of goat hair, and everything made of wood."[d]
21 Then Eleazar the priest said to the men of war who had gone to the battle, "This is the statute of the law that Yahweh has commanded Moses: 22 Only the gold, the silver, the bronze, the iron, the tin, and the lead, 23 everything that can withstand fire you shall put through the fire, and it shall be clean; yet it must also be purified with the water of impurity. And anything that cannot withstand fire you shall put through water. 24 You are to wash your clothes on the seventh day, and you will be clean. Afterward you may come into the camp."
25 Yahweh said to Moses, 26 "Take a count of the plunder that was captured, both of people and of animals, you and Eleazar the priest and the heads of the fathers' houses of the congregation. 27 Divide the spoil into two portions, between the soldiers who fought in the

battle and the rest of the congregation. [28] And set apart a levy for Yahweh from the soldiers who went out to battle: one in every five hundred, whether of persons, cattle, donkeys, or sheep and goats. [29] Take it from their half and give it to Eleazar the priest as a contribution to Yahweh. [30] And from the Israelites' half you shall take one in every fifty, whether of persons, cattle, donkeys, or sheep and goats —of all the animals—and give them to the Levites, who have charge of Yahweh's tabernacle." [31] And Moses and Eleazar the priest did as Yahweh commanded Moses.

[32] Now the plunder remaining of the spoil that the men of war had taken was 675,000 sheep, [33] 72,000 cattle, [34] 61,000 donkeys, [35] and 32,000 persons in all, women who had never had intercourse with a man. [36] The half portion of those who had gone to the war was, in number, 337,500 sheep and goats, [37] and Yahweh's tribute of sheep was 675. [38] The cattle were 36,000, of which Yahweh's tribute was 72. [39] The donkeys were 30,500, of which Yahweh's tribute was 61. [40] The persons were 16,000, of which Yahweh's tribute was 32 persons. [41] And Moses gave the tribute, which was Yahweh's contribution, to Eleazar the priest, as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

[42] As for the Israelites' half, which Moses had separated from the soldiers' share, [43] now the congregation's half was 337,500 sheep, [44] 36,000 cattle, [45] 30,500 donkeys, [46] and 16,000 persons. [47] From the Israelites' half Moses took one portion in fifty, whether human or animal, and gave them to the Levites who kept charge of Yahweh's tabernacle, just as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

[48] Then the officers who were over the thousands of the army, the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds, came near to Moses [49] and they said to Moses, "Your servants have taken the count of the soldiers in our charge, and not one of us is lacking. [50] So we have brought as an offering to Yahweh what each man found of gold ornaments—armlets, bracelets, signet rings, earrings, and necklaces—to make atonement for ourselves before Yahweh." [51] So Moses and Eleazar the priest received the gold from them, all of it in worked ornaments. [52] All the gold of the contribution that they presented to Yahweh, from the commanders of thousands and the commanders of

hundreds, came to about 420 pounds.[e] 53 (The men of war had taken plunder, each man for himself.) 54 And Moses and Eleazar the priest received the gold from the commanders of thousands and of hundreds and brought it into the tent of meeting as a reminder of the Israelites before Yahweh.

Notes

- a (31:5) Or "twelve units." On the Hebrew 'elef, "thousand" or "clan unit," see the note at 1:46.
- b (31:8) Evi perhaps means "desire." Rekem, "variegated." Zur, "rock." Hur, perhaps "white" or "child." Reba, "fourth" or "offspring."
- c (31:10) Hebrew tirot, walled encampments or circular settlements of tents.
- d (31:20) At about this point the Samaritan Pentateuch adds further instructions on purification. See the note at 10:10.
- e (31:52) Hebrew "16,750 shekels," about 193 kilograms. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams); standards varied.

Chapter 32

1 Now the descendants of Reuben and the descendants of Gad had a very great number of livestock. They saw the land of Jazer and the land of Gilead, and saw that the place was a place for livestock. 2 So the descendants of Gad and the descendants of Reuben came and spoke to Moses, to Eleazar the priest, and to the leaders of the congregation, saying, 3 "Ataroth, Dibon, Jazer, Nimrah, Heshbon, Elealeh, Sebam, Nebo, and Beon,[a] 4 the land that Yahweh struck down before the congregation of Israel, is a land for livestock, and your servants have livestock." 5 They continued, "If we have gained your favor, let this land be granted to your servants as our holding; do not bring us over the Jordan."

6 But Moses said to the descendants of Gad and to the descendants of Reuben, "Shall your brothers go to the war while you sit here? 7 Why would you discourage the Israelites from crossing over into the land that Yahweh has given them? 8 This is what your fathers did when I sent them from Kadesh-barnea to see the land. 9 For when they went up to the Valley of Eshcol and saw the land, they discouraged the Israelites from going into the land that Yahweh had given them. 10 And Yahweh's anger burned on that day, and he swore, saying, 11

‘Surely none of the men who came up out of Egypt, from twenty years
old and upward, will see the land that I swore to give to Abraham,
to Isaac, and to Jacob, because they have not followed me fully, 12
none except Caleb son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite[b] and Joshua son
of Nun, for they have followed Yahweh fully.’ 13 And Yahweh’s anger
burned against Israel, and he made them wander in the wilderness
forty years, until all the generation that had done evil in the eyes of
Yahweh was gone. 14 And now here you are, risen up in your fathers’
place, a brood of sinners, adding still more to Yahweh’s burning anger
against Israel! 15 For if you turn away from following him, he will
again abandon them in the wilderness, and you will destroy all this
people.”
16 Then they came near to him and said, “We will build sheepfolds here
for our livestock and cities for our little ones, 17 but we ourselves will
take up arms, ready to go before the Israelites, until we have brought
them to their place. And our little ones will live in the fortified cities
because of the inhabitants of the land. 18 We will not return to our
homes until each of the Israelites has received his inheritance. 19 For
we will not inherit with them on the other side of the Jordan and
beyond, because our inheritance has come to us on this side of the
Jordan to the east.”
20 Moses answered them, “If you will carry this out, and arm your-
selves to march before Yahweh into battle, 21 and every armed man of
you will cross the Jordan before Yahweh, until he has driven out his
enemies from before him 22 and the land is subdued before Yahweh,
then afterward you may return and be free of obligation to Yahweh
and to Israel, and this land will be your possession before Yahweh. 23
But if you will not do so, look, you have sinned against Yahweh, and
be sure your sin will find you out. 24 Build cities for your little ones
and folds for your sheep, and do what has come out of your mouth.”
25 And the descendants of Gad and the descendants of Reuben said to
Moses, “Your servants will do as my lord commands. 26 Our little ones,
our wives, our flocks, and all our livestock will remain there in the
cities of Gilead, 27 but your servants will cross over, every man who
is armed for war, before Yahweh to battle, as my lord says.”

28 So Moses gave command concerning them to Eleazar the priest, to
Joshua son of Nun, and to the heads of the fathers' houses of the tribes
of the Israelites. 29 And Moses said to them, "If the descendants of Gad
and the descendants of Reuben, every man who is armed to battle
before Yahweh, will cross over the Jordan with you and the land is
subdued before you, then you are to give them the land of Gilead as
a possession. 30 But if they will not cross over with you armed, they
are to have possessions among you in the land of Canaan." 31 And the
descendants of Gad and the descendants of Reuben answered, "What
Yahweh has said to your servants, that we will do. 32 We will cross over
armed before Yahweh into the land of Canaan, and the possession of
our inheritance will remain with us beyond the Jordan."
33 So Moses gave to them, to the descendants of Gad and to the descen-
dants of Reuben and to half the tribe of Manasseh son of Joseph, the
kingdom of Sihon king of the Amorites and the kingdom of Og king
of Bashan, the land with its cities and their territories, the cities of the
land throughout. 34 And the descendants of Gad built Dibon, Ataroth,
Aroer, 35 Atroth-shophan, Jazer, Jogbehah, 36 Beth-nimrah, and Beth-
haran, fortified cities, and folds for sheep. 37 And the descendants of
Reuben built Heshbon, Elealeh, Kiriathaim, 38 Nebo, Baal Meon (their
names were changed), and Sibmah; and they gave other names to the
cities they rebuilt.[c] 39 The sons of Machir the son of Manasseh went
to Gilead, captured it, and drove out the Amorites who were there. 40
So Moses gave Gilead to Machir son of Manasseh, and he settled in
it. 41 Jair son of Manasseh went and captured their villages and called
them Havvoth-jair.[d] 42 And Nobah went and captured Kenath and its
villages, and called it Nobah, after his own name.

Notes

- a (32:3) These are towns east of the Jordan. Sebam is probably Sibmah (verse 38), and Beon is Baal-meon (verse 38).
- b (32:12) The Kenizzites were a clan descended from Kenaz, an Edomite (Genesis 36:11), who joined Judah.
- c (32:38) Nebo and Baal-meon contain names of gods (Nabu and Baal), which may explain the renaming.
- d (32:41) Havvoth-jair means "tent villages of Jair."

Chapter 33

1 These are the stages of the journeys of the Israelites, when they came
out of the land of Egypt by their divisions under the leadership of
Moses and Aaron. 2 Moses wrote down their starting places, stage by
stage, at the command of Yahweh. These are their stages according to
their starting places. 3 They departed from Rameses in the first month,
on the fifteenth day of the first month (in March–April).[a] On the day
after the Passover the Israelites marched out boldly[b] in full view of all
the Egyptians, 4 while the Egyptians were burying all their firstborn,
whom Yahweh had struck down among them. On their gods also
Yahweh executed judgments.
5 So the Israelites set out from Rameses and camped at Succoth. 6
They set out from Succoth and camped at Etham, which is on the
edge of the wilderness. 7 They left Etham and turned back toward
Pi Hahiroth, which is east of Baal Zephon, and camped in front of
Migdol. 8 They left Hahiroth[c] and crossed the sea through its midst
into the wilderness; they traveled three days in the Wilderness of
Etham and camped at Marah. 9 They left Marah and came to Elim,
where there were twelve springs of water and seventy palm trees;
and they camped there. 10 They set out from Elim and camped by the
Red Sea. 11 They set out from the Red Sea and camped in the Wilder-
ness of Sin. 12 They set out from the Wilderness of Sin and camped
at Dophkah. 13 They set out from Dophkah and camped at Alush. 14
They set out from Alush and camped at Rephidim, where there was
no water for the people to drink. 15 They set out from Rephidim and
camped in the Wilderness of Sinai.
16 They set out from the Wilderness of Sinai and camped at Kibroth-
hattaavah.[d] 17 They set out from Kibroth-hattaavah and camped at
Hazeroth. 18 They set out from Hazeroth and camped at Rithmah. 19
They set out from Rithmah and camped at Rimmon-perez. 20 They set
out from Rimmon-perez and camped at Libnah. 21 They set out from
Libnah and camped at Rissah. 22 They set out from Rissah and camped
at Kehelathah. 23 They set out from Kehelathah and camped at Mount
Shepher. 24 They set out from Mount Shepher and camped at Haradah.
25 They set out from Haradah and camped at Makheloth. 26 They set

out from Makheloth and camped at Tahath. 27 They set out from Tahath and camped at Terah. 28 They set out from Terah and camped at Mithkah. 29 They set out from Mithkah and camped at Hashmonah. 30 They set out from Hashmonah and camped at Moseroth. 31 They set out from Moseroth and camped at Bene-jaakan. 32 They set out from Bene-jaakan and camped at Hor-haggidgad. 33 They set out from Hor-haggidgad and camped at Jotbathah. 34 They set out from Jotbathah and camped at Abronah. 35 They set out from Abronah and camped at Ezion-geber. 36 They set out from Ezion-geber and camped in the Wilderness of Zin, that is, Kadesh. 37 They set out from Kadesh and camped at Mount Hor, on the edge of the land of Edom.

38 Aaron the priest went up Mount Hor at the command of Yahweh and died there, in the fortieth year after the Israelites had come out of the land of Egypt, on the first day of the fifth month (in July–August).[e] 39 Aaron was a hundred twenty-three years old when he died on Mount Hor.

40 And the Canaanite, the king of Arad, who lived in the Negev in the land of Canaan, heard of the coming of the Israelites.

41 They set out from Mount Hor and camped at Zalmonah. 42 They set out from Zalmonah and camped at Punon. 43 They set out from Punon and camped at Oboth. 44 They set out from Oboth and camped at Iye-abarim, on the border of Moab. 45 They set out from Iyim[f] and camped at Dibon-gad. 46 They set out from Dibon-gad and camped at Almon-diblathaim. 47 They set out from Almon-diblathaim and camped in the mountains of Abarim, before Nebo. 48 They set out from the mountains of Abarim and camped in the plains of Moab by the Jordan at Jericho. 49 They camped by the Jordan from Beth-jeshimoth as far as Abel-shittim[g] in the plains of Moab.

50 Yahweh spoke to Moses in the plains of Moab by the Jordan at Jericho, saying, 51 "Speak to the Israelites and say to them, 'When you cross the Jordan into the land of Canaan, 52 then you are to drive out all the inhabitants of the land from before you and destroy all their carved stones,[h] destroy all their metal images, and demolish all their high places. 53 You are to take possession of the land and settle in it, for I have given the land to you to possess. 54 You are to inherit the land

by lot according to your clans. To a large clan you are to give a larger inheritance, and to a small clan you are to give a smaller inheritance. Wherever the lot falls for anyone, that is to be his. You are to inherit according to the tribes of your fathers. 55 But if you do not drive out the inhabitants of the land ahead of you, those you allow to remain will become barbs in your eyes and thorns in your sides, and they will harass you in the land where you live. 56 And as I thought to do to them, so I will do to you.'"

Notes

- a (33:3) First month: Abib, later called Nisan, of the spring-start religious calendar. Because the months were lunar, the date falls in different parts of March and April from year to year. Compare Exodus 12:2–6, 51.
- b (33:3) Hebrew "with a high hand."
- c (33:8) Some Hebrew manuscripts and ancient versions read "Pi-hahiroth," as in verse 7.
- d (33:16) Verses 16–36 list stopping places, many of which are found only here and cannot now be located. Some names describe features: Rithmah, "broom bush"; Rimmon-perez, "pomegranate of the breach"; Libnah, "white"; Haradah, "trembling"; Makheloth, "assemblies"; Moseroth, "bonds"; Bene-jaakan, "sons of Jaakan"; Jotbathah, "pleasantness"; Ezion-geber, perhaps "backbone of a man," at the head of the Gulf of Aqaba.
- e (33:38) Fifth month: Av, of the spring-start religious calendar. Because the months were lunar, the date falls in different parts of July and August from year to year. This is the only place in the Bible where the date of Aaron's death is given.
- f (33:45) Iyim, "ruins," is a short form of Iye-abarim (verse 44).
- g (33:49) Beth-jeshimoth means "house of the wastes." Abel-shittim means "meadow of acacias"; compare Shittim in 25:1.
- h (33:52) Or "figured stones," carved images used in worship.

Chapter 34

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 2 "Command the Israelites and tell them: When you enter Canaan (this is the land that shall fall to you as an inheritance—Canaan according to its boundaries), 3 your southern side shall run from the Wilderness of Zin alongside Edom, and your southern boundary shall begin at the eastern end of the Salt Sea;[a] 4 your border shall turn southward of the Akrabbim Pass,[b] continue on to Zin, and end south of Kadesh Barnea; it shall extend to Hazar

Addar and pass along to Azmon; 5 The border is to turn from Azmon
to the Brook of Egypt,[c] and its limit is to be at the sea.
6 "'For the western border you are to have the Great Sea[d] and its coast.
This is to be your western border.
7 "'This is to be your northern border: from the Great Sea you are
to mark out your line to Mount Hor.[e] 8 From Mount Hor you are to
mark it out to Lebo-hamath, and the limit of the border is to be at
Zedad. 9 Then the border is to extend to Ziphron, and its limit is to be
at Hazar-enan. This is to be your northern border.
10 "'You are to mark out your eastern border from Hazar-enan to
Shepham. 11 The border is to go down from Shepham to Riblah on the
east side of Ain. And the border is to go down and reach the slope
east of the Sea of Chinnereth.[f] 12 And the border is to go down to the
Jordan, and its limit is to be at the Salt Sea. This is to be your land
with its borders all around.'"
13 Moses commanded the Israelites, saying, "This is the land that you
are to inherit by lot, which Yahweh has commanded to give to the
nine tribes and to the half-tribe. 14 The tribe of Reuben's sons by
their ancestral houses, and the tribe of Gad's sons by their ancestral
houses, and half the tribe of Manasseh have already received their
inheritance. 15 The two tribes and the half-tribe have received their
inheritance beyond the Jordan at Jericho, eastward, toward the sun-
rise."
16 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 17 "These are the names of the men
who are to divide the land to you for inheritance: Eleazar the priest
and Joshua son of Nun. 18 You shall take one leader from every tribe
to apportion the land as an inheritance. 19 These are the names of the
men: Of the tribe of Judah, Caleb son of Jephunneh. 20 Of the tribe of
the descendants of Simeon, Shemuel son of Ammihud. 21 Of the tribe
of Benjamin, Elidad son of Chislon. 22 Of the tribe of the descendants
of Dan a leader, Bukki son of Jogli. 23 Of the descendants of Joseph:
of the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh a leader, Hanniel son of
Ephod. 24 And of the tribe of the descendants of Ephraim a leader,
Kemuel son of Shiphtan. 25 Of the tribe of the descendants of Zebulun
a leader, Elizaphan son of Parnach. 26 Of the tribe of the descendants

of Issachar a leader, Paltiel son of Azzan. 27 And of the tribe of the descendants of Asher a leader, Ahihud son of Shelomi. 28 Of the tribe of the descendants of Naphtali a leader, Pedahel son of Ammihud.[g] 29 These are the ones whom Yahweh commanded to divide the inheritance to the Israelites in the land of Canaan."

Notes

- a (34:3) That is, the Dead Sea.
- b (34:4) Akrabbim means "scorpions."
- c (34:5) Probably the Wadi el-Arish in northern Sinai.
- d (34:6) That is, the Mediterranean Sea.
- e (34:7) Not the Mount Hor of 20:22, but a mountain in the north, probably in the Lebanon range.
- f (34:11) That is, the Sea of Galilee. Chinnereth may mean "harp-shaped."
- g (34:28) Several of these names are theophoric: Shemuel, "name of God"; Elidad, "God has loved"; Hanniel, "grace of God"; Kemuel, perhaps "assembly of God"; Elizaphan, "God has protected"; Paltiel, "God is my deliverance"; Pedahel, "God has redeemed." Bukki perhaps means "proved"; Ahihud, "my brother is majesty."

Chapter 35

1 Yahweh spoke to Moses in the plains of Moab by the Jordan at Jericho, saying, 2 "Command the Israelites to give the Levites towns to live in out of the inheritance they possess; and you shall give the Levites open pastureland around the towns. 3 The cities are to be theirs to live in, and their pasturelands are to be for their cattle, for their possessions, and for all their animals. 4 The pasturelands of the cities, which you are to give to the Levites, are to reach from the wall of the city outward 1,500 feet[a] all around. 5 And you are to measure outside the city, on the east side 3,000 feet,[b] on the south side 3,000 feet, on the west side 3,000 feet, and on the north side 3,000 feet, with the city in the middle. This is to be the pastureland of their cities.
6 "The towns you give the Levites shall include the six cities of refuge, which you shall designate for a killer to flee to; and in addition you shall give forty-two towns. 7 All the cities that you give to the Levites are to be forty-eight cities with their pasturelands. 8 As for the cities that you give from the possession of the Israelites, from the larger tribes you are to take many, and from the smaller tribes you are to

take few. Each is to give some of its cities to the Levites, in proportion to the inheritance that it receives."
9 Yahweh spoke to Moses, saying, 10 "Speak to the Israelites and say to them, 'When you cross the Jordan into the land of Canaan, 11 then you are to select cities to be cities of refuge for you, so that the manslayer who kills any person unintentionally may flee there. 12 The cities are to be for you a refuge from the avenger,[c] so that the manslayer may not die until he stands before the congregation for judgment. 13 The cities that you give are to be your six cities of refuge. 14 Three cities you shall give on this side of the Jordan, and three cities in the land of Canaan; they shall be cities of refuge. 15 These six cities are to be for refuge for the Israelites, and for the foreigner and the resident alien among them, so that anyone who kills a person unintentionally may flee there.
16 "But if he strikes him with an iron tool so that he dies, he is a murderer; the murderer shall surely be put to death. 17 And if he strikes him with a stone held in the hand, of a size that could kill, and he dies, he is a murderer; the murderer shall surely be put to death. 18 Or if he struck him down with a wooden object in the hand, by which a man may die, and he died, he is a murderer. The murderer must be put to death. 19 The avenger of blood himself is to put the murderer to death. When he meets him, he is to put him to death. 20 Or if in hatred he shoves him, or hurls something at him from ambush so that he dies, 21 or in enmity hits him with his fist and he dies, the one who hit him is to be put to death, for he is a murderer; the avenger of blood shall kill the murderer upon meeting him.
22 "'But if he pushed him suddenly without enmity, or threw anything at him without lying in wait, 23 or, using any stone that could kill, drops it on him without seeing him, so that he dies, though he was not his enemy and was not seeking his harm, 24 then the congregation shall decide between the one who struck and the blood avenger on the basis of these rules. 25 The congregation shall rescue the killer from the avenger of blood, and the congregation shall return him to his city of refuge where he had fled; and he shall live there until the death of the high priest who was anointed with the holy oil. 26 But if

the killer ever leaves the boundary of the city of refuge where he fled,
27 and the blood avenger finds him outside the boundary of his city of
refuge and kills the slayer, no bloodguilt attaches to him, 28 because
the killer must stay in his city of refuge until the high priest dies; only
after the high priest's death may the slayer go back to his own landed
property. 29 These shall be a legal ordinance for you through all your
generations, wherever you live.
30 "If anyone kills a person, the murderer shall be put to death at
the word of witnesses; but one witness alone cannot testify against
a person to bring about his death. 31 Moreover, you are to accept no
ransom for the life of a murderer who is guilty of death. He must be
put to death. 32 And you shall take no ransom for someone who has
fled to his city of refuge, to allow him to go back and live on his land
before the high priest dies. 33 Do not pollute the land you are in, for
blood pollutes the land, and the land cannot be atoned for regarding
the blood poured out in it, except by the blood of the person who
poured it out. 34 Do not make unclean the land where you live, in
whose midst I dwell; for I, Yahweh, dwell among the Israelites."

Notes

- a (35:4) Hebrew "a thousand cubits," about 450 meters. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters).
- b (35:5) Hebrew "two thousand cubits," about 900 meters. The relation between verses 4 and 5 is uncertain; verse 5 may give the length of each side of a square around the city.
- c (35:12) Hebrew go'el, the nearest relative, responsible for avenging a killing. See the note at 5:8.

Chapter 36

1 The family heads of the clan of Gilead's descendants, the son of
Machir, son of Manasseh, from the Joseph clans, came near and spoke
in the presence of Moses and the leaders, the family heads of the
Israelites. 2 They said, "Yahweh commanded my lord to distribute
the land by lot as an inheritance to the Israelites, and my lord
was commanded by Yahweh to give the inheritance of our brother
Zelophehad to his daughters. 3 Yet if they marry sons from another
Israelite tribe, their inheritance will be removed from our ancestral

inheritance and added to the inheritance of the tribe they join; thus it will be cut off from the allotment of our inheritance. 4 And when the Israelites' Jubilee[a] arrives, their inheritance will be added to that of the tribe they have joined, and their inheritance will be cut off from our ancestral tribe's inheritance."

5 So Moses commanded the Israelites according to the word of Yahweh, saying, "The tribe of the descendants of Joseph is right. 6 This is the command of Yahweh for Zelophehad's daughters: they may marry anyone they choose, but only within a family of their father's tribe. 7 The inheritance of the Israelites is not to pass from tribe to tribe, for every one of the Israelites is to hold on to the inheritance of the tribe of his fathers. 8 Every daughter who holds an inheritance in any Israelite tribe shall marry someone from a family of her father's tribe, so that each Israelite keeps his ancestral inheritance. 9 No inheritance shall be transferred from one tribe to another, for the Israelite tribes shall each keep to their own inheritance.'"

10 The daughters of Zelophehad did as Yahweh commanded Moses. 11 Mahlah, Tirzah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Noah, Zelophehad's daughters, married their cousins on their father's side. 12 They were married into the clans of the descendants of Manasseh son of Joseph, and their inheritance remained in the tribe of their father's clan.

13 These are the commands and ordinances that Yahweh gave to the Israelites through Moses on the plains of Moab by the Jordan across from Jericho.

Notes

- a (36:4) The Jubilee was the fiftieth year, when land returned to its original family owners (Leviticus 25:8–17).

Deuteronomy

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 These are the words that Moses addressed to all Israel across
the Jordan, in the wilderness, in the Arabah[a] facing Suph,[b] in the
region between Paran and Tophel, Laban, Hazeroth, and Di-zahab.[c]
2 It is an eleven-day journey from Horeb[d] by the Mount Seir road
to Kadesh-barnea. 3 In the fortieth year, in the eleventh month (in
January–February), on the first day of the month,[e] Moses spoke to
the Israelites, telling them everything Yahweh[f] had commanded him
to tell them. 4 He spoke after he had struck down Sihon, the Amorite
king who ruled from Heshbon, and Og, the king of Bashan who ruled
from Ashtaroth and[g] from Edrei. 5 Beyond the Jordan, in the land of
Moab, Moses undertook to explain this instruction.[h] He said:
6 "At Horeb Yahweh our God said to us: 'You have lived long enough
at this mountain. 7 Turn and set out. Go to the hill country of the
Amorites and to all their neighbors in the Arabah, the hill country, the
Shephelah,[i] the Negev,[j] and the seacoast—the land of the Canaanites
—and to Lebanon, as far as the great river, the Euphrates. 8 Look, I
have laid the land open before you. Go in and take over the land that
Yahweh swore[k] he would give to your forefathers Abraham, Isaac,
and Jacob, and to their offspring after them.'
9 "At that time I told you, 'I cannot carry you by myself. 10 Yahweh your
God has increased your numbers, and look, today you are as countless
as the stars of heaven. 11 May Yahweh, the God of your ancestors,
make you a thousand times as many as you are now and bless you as
he promised you! 12 How can I alone bear the weight and burden of
you and your quarrels? 13 Pick men from each of your tribes who are
wise, discerning, and well known, and I will make them your heads.'
14 You replied to me, 'The thing you have spoken of doing is good.'
15 So I took the heads of your tribes, wise and well-known men, and

made them heads over you—commanders of thousands, of hundreds, of fifties, and of tens—and officials for your tribes. 16 At that time I charged your judges: 'Hear the cases between your fellow Israelites[l] and decide rightly between a man and his brother, or the foreigner who lives with him. 17 Show no favoritism in judgment; hear the small and the great alike. Fear no one, for the judgment is God's. Any case too hard for you, bring to me, and I will hear it.' 18 I gave you orders at that time about everything you were to do.

19 "Then we set out from Horeb and went through all that vast and terrible wilderness you saw, on the way to the hill country of the Amorites, as Yahweh our God had commanded us, and we came to Kadesh-barnea. 20 I said to you, 'You have come to the hill country of the Amorites, which Yahweh our God is giving us. 21 Look, Yahweh your God has set the land before you. Go up and take it, as Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, has told you. Do not fear or lose heart.'

22 "Then you all approached me and said, 'We should send men on ahead to explore the land for us and to bring back a report on the route we should take up and the cities we will reach.' 23 The idea pleased me, so I chose twelve men from among you, a man for each tribe. 24 They turned and went up into the hill country, came to the Valley of Eshcol,[m] and spied it out. 25 They took some of the land's fruit in their hands, brought it down to us, and reported, 'The land Yahweh our God is giving us is good.' 26 "Yet you would not go up. You rebelled against the command of Yahweh your God. 27 You complained in your tents and said, 'Because Yahweh hates us he brought us out of the land of Egypt, to hand us over to the Amorites to wipe us out. 28 Where are we going up to? Our brothers have made our hearts melt. They say, "The people are greater and taller than we are; the cities are great and walled up to the sky. And we saw the sons of the Anakim[n] there."' 29 "I said to you, 'Do not dread them or fear them. 30 Yahweh your God, who is going ahead of you, is the one who will fight on your behalf, exactly as he did for you in Egypt, before your very eyes, 31 and in the wilderness, where you saw how Yahweh your God bore you as a father bears his child, all along the way you walked until you reached this place.' 32 Yet in this matter you did not trust Yahweh

your God, [33] who went before you on the way to seek out a place for you to camp, in fire by night to show you the road you should take, and in the cloud by day.
[34] "Yahweh heard the sound of your words and was angry, and he swore: [35] 'Not a single man of this wicked generation shall look on the good land that I swore to give your forefathers, [36] save Caleb[o] the son of Jephunneh; he shall see it, and I will give him and his sons the land on which he walked, because he wholly followed Yahweh.' [37] Even with me Yahweh was angry because of you, and he said, 'You also will not go in there. [38] Joshua[p] son of Nun, who stands before you, he will go in there. Strengthen him, for he will make Israel inherit it. [39] Your little ones, about whom you said they would be taken as spoil,[q] and your sons, who as yet have no understanding of good or bad, will enter it; to them I will give it, and they will inherit it. [40] But you, turn back and set out into the wilderness by way of the Red Sea.'[r] [41] "Then you answered me, 'We have sinned against Yahweh. We ourselves will go up and fight, in keeping with all that Yahweh our God commanded us.' So every man girded on his weapons of war, regarding the ascent into the hill country as a trifle. [42] But Yahweh told me, 'Tell them, "Do not go up, and do not fight, because I am not among you; otherwise your enemies will defeat you."' [43] I spoke to you, but you would not listen. You rebelled against Yahweh's command, and in your presumption you went up into the hill country. [44] Then the Amorites who lived in that hill country came out against you and chased you as bees do, and beat you down from Seir[s] as far as Hormah. [45] So you returned and wept before Yahweh; but Yahweh would not hear your voice, nor give ear to you. [46] So you remained at Kadesh many days, as many days as you remained there.

Notes

- a (1:1) The Arabah is the great rift valley running south from the Sea of Galilee, through the Jordan Valley and the Dead Sea, down to the Gulf of Aqaba.
- b (1:1) Hebrew Suph, "reeds," perhaps short for Yam Suph, the Sea of Reeds; the Septuagint has "near the Red Sea." The locations of the places named in this verse are uncertain.

- c (1:1) Di-zahab means “abundance of gold”; the Septuagint translates it “the gold works.” Paran perhaps means “place of caves”; Laban means “white”; Hazeroth means “enclosures” or “villages.”
- d (1:2) Horeb (perhaps “dry” or “desolate”) is the name Deuteronomy usually gives to the mountain called Sinai in Exodus. Kadesh-barnea: Kadesh means “holy.”
- e (1:3) Hebrew “in the eleventh month,” later called Shevat. This translation counts the months from the spring new year (Nisan, also called Abib, in March–April). The Hebrew calendar is lunar, so modern equivalents are approximate.
- f (1:3) Yahweh is the personal name of Israel’s God (Hebrew YHWH), which many English versions replace with “the LORD”; see Exodus 3:14–15. Moses means “drawn out” (Exodus 2:10).
- g (1:4) So the Septuagint (compare Joshua 12:4); the Hebrew lacks “and.” Sihon’s name may mean “sweeping away”; Og’s is of uncertain meaning; Heshbon means “reckoning”; Ashtaroth is named for the goddess Astarte; Edrei may mean “strength.”
- h (1:5) Or “law.” Hebrew torah means instruction or teaching, and in Deuteronomy it often refers to the body of teaching Moses gives.
- i (1:7) The Shephelah (“lowland”) is the band of low hills between the central highlands and the coastal plain.
- j (1:7) The Negev (“dry land”) is the arid south of the land.
- k (1:8) Hebrew “that Yahweh swore to your fathers.” The Septuagint reads “which I swore,” and other ancient witnesses are reported to agree.
- l (1:16) Hebrew “your brothers,” here and often in Deuteronomy for fellow members of the people of Israel.
- m (1:24) Eshcol means “cluster” (of grapes); see Numbers 13:23–24. The Septuagint translates the name “the valley of the cluster.”
- n (1:28) The Anakim were a people remembered for their great size; Anak may mean “long-necked.” The Septuagint has “the sons of the giants.”
- o (1:36) Caleb probably means “dog,” perhaps in the sense of a faithful servant; Jephunneh is of uncertain meaning.
- p (1:38) Joshua means “Yahweh saves.” Nun may mean “fish”; the Septuagint spells the name “Naue.”
- q (1:39) The Septuagint lacks “who you said would become plunder.”
- r (1:40) Hebrew Yam Suph, “Sea of Reeds,” here probably the Gulf of Aqaba.
- s (1:44) So the Septuagint and other ancient versions; the Hebrew reads “in Seir.” Hormah means “destruction” or “place devoted to destruction.”

Chapter 2

[1] “Then we turned and set out into the wilderness by way of the Red Sea, as Yahweh had told me, and for many days we went around Mount Seir.

2 “Then Yahweh said to me, 3 ‘You have been going around this hill
country long enough. Turn north. 4 Give the people this order: “You
are about to pass along the border of your kinsmen, Esau’s descen-
dants,[a] who live in Seir. They will be afraid of you, so be very careful.
5 Do not start a fight with them, for I will not give you any of their
land, not so much as a footprint, because I have given Mount Seir to
Esau as his own. 6 You are to buy the food you eat from them with
silver, and you are also to buy the water you drink from them with
silver. 7 For Yahweh your God has blessed you in all that your hands
have done. He has known your going through this great wilderness.
For these forty years Yahweh your God has been with you; you have
lacked nothing.”’ 8 “So we went on past our kinsmen, the sons of Esau,
who dwell in Seir, away from the Arabah road, away from Elath and
Ezion Geber.[b] And we turned and traveled the way of the wilderness
of Moab. 9 Yahweh told me, ‘Do not treat Moab as an enemy or go
to war with them. I will not give you any part of their land to own,
because I have assigned Ar[c] to Lot’s descendants[d] as their own.’ 10 (The
Emim[e] lived there formerly, a people great and many and tall as the
Anakim. 11 They also were reckoned as Rephaim,[f] like the Anakim,
but the Moabites call them Emim. 12 The Horites[g] also used to live
in Seir, but Esau’s descendants dispossessed them, wiped them out,
and took over their land, just as Israel was to do in the land Yahweh
gave them to own.) 13 ‘Now get up and cross the Wadi Zered.’[h] So we
crossed the Wadi Zered. 14 We spent thirty-eight years getting from
Kadesh-barnea to the crossing of the Wadi Zered. By then that whole
generation of soldiers had died out of the camp, as Yahweh had sworn
to them. 15 Indeed, the hand of Yahweh was against them, to root them
out from the midst of the camp until they had perished.
16 “When all the men of war had died and were gone from among the
people, 17 Yahweh spoke to me: 18 ‘Today you are crossing the border of
Moab at Ar. 19 And when you approach the border of the Ammonites,
do not harass them or provoke them to battle; for I will give you no
part of the Ammonites’ land as a possession, since I have given it to
the sons of Lot for a possession.’ 20 (That also is reckoned a land of
Rephaim. Rephaim lived there formerly, but the Ammonites call them

Zamzummim,[i] 21 a people great and many and tall as the Anakim.
But Yahweh destroyed them before the Ammonites, and they drove
them out and settled in their place, 22 just as he had done for Esau's
descendants who live in Seir, when he wiped out the Horites ahead
of them; they dispossessed them and occupy their land to this day.
23 And the Avvim,[j] who lived in villages as far as Gaza, were wiped
out by the Caphtorim,[k] who had come from Caphtor and then took
over their land.) 24 'Get up, set out, and cross the Arnon Valley.[l] See, I
have put into your hand Sihon the Amorite, king of Heshbon, and his
land. Begin to take possession; fight him in battle. 25 This day I will
begin to put the dread and fear of you on the peoples everywhere
under heaven. When they hear the report of you, they will tremble
and writhe in anguish because of you.'
26 "So I sent messengers from the wilderness of Kedemoth[m] to Sihon
king of Heshbon with words of peace: 27 'Let me pass through your
land. I will go only along the road; I will turn neither to the right nor
to the left. 28 Sell me food for silver so that I may eat, and give me
water for silver so that I may drink. Only let me go through on foot, 29
Esau's descendants in Seir did this for me, and so did the Moabites in
Ar. Let me go on until I have crossed the Jordan into the land Yahweh
our God is giving us.' 30 But Sihon king of Heshbon would not let
us pass by him, for Yahweh your God had hardened his spirit and
made his heart stubborn, in order to give him into your hand, as he
is today. 31 Then Yahweh said to me, 'See, I have begun to give Sihon
and his land over to you. Begin to take possession, so that you may
possess his land.' 32 Sihon came out against us, he and all his people,
to battle at Jahaz. 33 But Yahweh our God gave him up to us, and we
defeated him, his sons,[n] and all his people. 34 We captured all his cities
at that time and devoted[o] every city to destruction, men and women
and little ones. We left no survivor. 35 Only the livestock we took as
plunder for ourselves, with the spoil of the cities we had captured. 36
From Aroer on the rim of the Arnon gorge, and from the city in the
gorge, as far as Gilead, no town was too lofty for us; Yahweh our God
handed over all of them to us. 37 Only you did not go near the land of

the Ammonites, the whole bank of the Jabbok River,[p] or the cities of the hill country, or any place Yahweh our God had forbidden.

Notes

- a (2:4) Esau means "hairy"; see Genesis 25:25. Seir also suggests "hairy," perhaps of its wooded slopes.
- b (2:8) Elath ("terebinth") and Ezion-geber were at the head of the Gulf of Aqaba.
- c (2:9) Ar ("city") was a city or district of Moab.
- d (2:9) Lot may mean "covering." Moab and Ammon descended from him (Genesis 19:36–38).
- e (2:10) Emim means "terrors."
- f (2:11) The Rephaim were an ancient people remembered as giants; the same word elsewhere means the "shades" of the dead.
- g (2:12) The Horites may be "cave dwellers," or the name may refer to the Hurrians.
- h (2:13) Hebrew nahal, a valley with a stream that flows mainly in the rainy season. Zered may mean "willow" or "luxuriant growth."
- i (2:20) Zamzummim may mean "murmurers"; the meaning is uncertain.
- j (2:23) Avvim may mean "ruins."
- k (2:23) Caphtor is usually identified with Crete; the Philistines came from there (Amos 9:7).
- l (2:24) The Arnon is the gorge east of the Dead Sea that formed Moab's northern border; its name may mean "roaring stream."
- m (2:26) Kedemoth means "eastern places." Jahaz (verse 32) may mean "trodden place."
- n (2:33) So the Hebrew reading tradition (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "his son."
- o (2:34) Hebrew herem: to give something over completely to God, which in war meant its total destruction.
- p (2:37) The Jabbok, perhaps "flowing," is a tributary that runs west into the Jordan.

Chapter 3

1 "Then we turned and went up the road to Bashan, and Og king of Bashan came out against us, he and all his people, to battle at Edrei. 2 But Yahweh told me, 'Have no fear of him, for into your hand I have given him, his whole people, and his land; deal with him as you dealt with Sihon, king of the Amorites, who made his home in Heshbon.' 3 So Yahweh our God also delivered into our hands Og the king of Bashan with all his people; we struck them down until not one was left of them. 4 At that time we took all his cities; not one of the towns was left that we did not seize from them—sixty cities, the entire

district of Argob,[a] Og's kingdom in Bashan. 5 All these were cities
fortified with high walls, gates, and bars, besides a great many open
villages. 6 We devoted them to destruction, as we had done to Sihon
king of Heshbon, devoting every city to destruction, men, women,
and little ones. 7 But all the livestock and the spoil of the cities we
took as plunder for ourselves. 8 "So at that time we took the land out
of the hand of the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the
Jordan, from the Arnon Valley to Mount Hermon[b] 9 (the Sidonians
call Hermon Sirion, and the Amorites call it Senir), 10 all the cities of
the plateau, all of Gilead, and all of Bashan, to Salecah and Edrei, the
cities of Og's kingdom in Bashan. 11 (For only Og king of Bashan was
left of the remnant of the Rephaim. Look, his bed[c] was a bed of iron.
Is it not still in Rabbah of the Ammonites? It is about thirteen and
a half feet long and six feet wide, measured by a man's forearm.[d]) 12
"This is the land that we took possession of at that time: from Aroer,
on the edge of the Arnon gorge, and half of the hill country of Gilead
with its cities, I gave to the Reubenites and the Gadites. 13 The rest
of Gilead and all Bashan, the kingdom of Og, I gave to the half-tribe
of Manasseh. (The whole region of Argob, all that Bashan, is called a
land of Rephaim. 14 Jair[e] the Manassite captured all the Argob region
up to the Geshurite and Maacathite frontier, and he named Bashan
after himself, Havvoth-jair,[f] the name it still has today.) 15 To Machir[g]
I gave Gilead. 16 To the tribes of Reuben and Gad I assigned the land
stretching from Gilead down to the Arnon Valley (the middle of the
gorge forming the boundary) and up to the Jabbok River, which is the
Ammonite border, 17 and also the Arabah, with the Jordan as a border,
from Chinnereth[h] as far as the Sea of the Arabah, the Salt Sea,[i] under
the slopes of Pisgah[j] to the east.
18 "At that time I commanded you: 'Yahweh your God has given you
this land to possess. All you who are fit for war shall cross over armed
before your fellow Israelites. 19 Only your wives, your little ones, and
your livestock (I know that you have much livestock) shall stay in the
towns I have given you, 20 until Yahweh gives your kinsmen rest as he
has given you, and they too take over the land Yahweh your God is
giving them across the Jordan. After that, every man may go back to

the property I have given him.' 21 "And at that time I charged Joshua:
'Your own eyes have seen everything Yahweh your God did to these
two kings; Yahweh will do the same to all the kingdoms through
which you will pass. 22 Do not fear them, for it is Yahweh your God
who fights for you.'
23 "At that time I begged Yahweh for mercy: 24 'Lord Yahweh,[k] you
have begun to let your servant see your greatness and your strong
hand. Is there a god anywhere in the heavens or on the earth whose
works and mighty deeds can compare with yours? 25 Let me cross
over, I pray, and see the good land on the other side of the Jordan—
that fine hill country, and the Lebanon.' 26 But Yahweh was angry with
me because of you and would not listen to me. Yahweh said to me,
'Enough from you! Speak to me no more of this matter. 27 Climb to the
summit of Pisgah and look around, westward, northward, southward,
and eastward. Look at it well with your own eyes, because you will
not cross this Jordan. 28 Give Joshua his orders, encourage him, and
make him strong, because he is the one who will cross over leading
this people, and he is the one who will hand over to them the land you
are about to see.' 29 And so we stayed on in the valley facing Beth-peor.[l]

Notes

- a (3:4) Argob may mean "heap of stones."
- b (3:8) Hermon means "sacred" or "devoted." Sirion and Senir may both mean "breastplate," perhaps from the mountain's shining snow.
- c (3:11) Or "his coffin" or "sarcophagus"; the Hebrew word usually means a bed or couch.
- d (3:11) Hebrew "nine cubits its length and four cubits its width, by the cubit of a man," about 4 by 1.8 meters. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters).
- e (3:14) Jair means "he gives light."
- f (3:14) Havvoth-jair means "tent villages of Jair."
- g (3:15) Machir means "sold." He was Manasseh's son (Genesis 50:23); Manasseh means "causing to forget" (Genesis 41:51).
- h (3:17) Chinnereth (perhaps "harp-shaped") is the Sea of Galilee.
- i (3:17) The Dead Sea.
- j (3:17) Pisgah is a ridge of the Abarim mountains northeast of the Dead Sea, near Mount Nebo.
- k (3:24) Hebrew Adonai YHWH.
- l (3:29) Beth-peor means "house of Peor," a place linked with the worship of the Baal of Peor (Numbers 25).

Chapter 4

1 “And now, Israel, listen to the statutes and the rulings I am teaching
you to do, so that you may live, and go in and possess the land that
Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, is giving you. 2 Do not add to the
word I command you or take anything from it, so that you may keep
the commands of Yahweh your God that I am giving you. 3 Your own
eyes saw what Yahweh did at Baal-peor.[a] Every man who went after
the Baal of Peor, Yahweh your God wiped out from among you, 4 but
all of you who clung to Yahweh your God are alive today. 5 See, I have
taught you statutes and rulings, as Yahweh my God commanded me,
for you to do in the land you are entering to possess. 6 Guard them and
practice them, because this will show your wisdom and good sense
to the nations. Hearing of all these statutes, they will exclaim, ‘What
a wise and discerning people this great nation is!’ 7 For what great
nation is there that has gods so near to it as Yahweh our God is to
us whenever we call to him? 8 Or what great nation has statutes and
ordinances so just as this whole law which I set before you today?
9 “But be on your guard, and watch yourself carefully, so you will not
forget what you have seen with your own eyes, or let it slip from your
mind for as long as you live. Teach it to your children and to their
children. 10 Remember the day you stood in the presence of Yahweh
your God at Horeb, when Yahweh told me, ‘Call the people together
to me, so that I may have them hear my words, that they may learn
to revere me for as long as they live on the earth, and may teach their
children so.’ 11 You drew near and stood at the base of the mountain,
and the mountain was ablaze with fire reaching into the very heart of
the sky, wrapped in darkness, cloud, and thick gloom. 12 Then Yahweh
spoke to you out of the fire. You heard words being spoken, but you
saw no shape—only a voice. 13 He declared to you his covenant, which
he commanded you to perform, the Ten Words,[b] and he wrote them
on two tablets of stone. 14 And Yahweh commanded me at that time
to teach you statutes and rulings, for you to do them in the land you
are crossing into to possess.
15 “Therefore be very careful about yourselves, since you saw no form
on the day Yahweh spoke to you at Horeb out of the midst of the

fire, [16] so that you do not act corruptly by making yourselves a carved
image, in the form of any figure, the likeness of male or female, [17] the
likeness of any beast that is on the earth, the likeness of any winged
bird that flies in the sky, [18] the likeness of anything that creeps on the
ground, the likeness of any fish that is in the water under the earth.
[19] And take heed lest you lift your eyes to heaven and see the sun, the
moon, and the stars, the whole host of heaven, and be drawn away
to worship and serve them—those Yahweh your God has assigned to
all the nations under all of heaven. [20] But Yahweh has taken you and
brought you out from Egypt, the iron smelting furnace, to be his own
people, his inheritance, as you are today. [21] But Yahweh was angry
with me on your account and swore that I would not go across the
Jordan or come into the good land that Yahweh your God is giving
you to inherit. [22] For I will die in this land, without crossing the Jordan;
but you will go over and inherit this good land. [23] Take care not to
forget the covenant of Yahweh your God that he made with you,
and do not make yourselves a carved image in the form of anything
Yahweh your God has forbidden you. [24] For Yahweh your God is a fire
that consumes, a jealous God.
[25] "After you have had children and grandchildren and have grown
old in the land, if you then become corrupt and make an idol in any
shape, and do evil in the sight of Yahweh your God and provoke him,
[26] I summon heaven and earth today to testify against you: you will
quickly vanish from the land you are about to cross the Jordan to take
over. You will not live there long; you will be completely wiped out. [27]
Yahweh will scatter you among the peoples, and you will be left few
in number among the nations where Yahweh will drive you. [28] There
you will serve gods that are the work of human hands, wood and
stone, which neither see nor hear nor eat nor smell. [29] But from there
you will search for Yahweh your God, and you will find him, provided
you seek him with your whole heart and your whole being. [30] When
you are in distress and all these things have found you in the latter
days, you will return to Yahweh your God and obey his voice. [31] For
Yahweh your God is a merciful God. He will not fail you or ruin you,

and he will not forget the covenant he made with your forefathers
and confirmed by oath.
32 "Go on, ask about the days long past, the ages before you, back to
the day God created humankind[c] on the earth. Ask from one horizon
of the sky to the other: has any event as great as this ever taken place?
Has anyone ever heard of such a thing? 33 Has any people ever heard
the voice of a god[d] speaking from the middle of the fire, as you have
heard, and still lived? 34 Or has any god ever tried to go and take a
nation for himself from within another nation, by trials, by signs, by
wonders, by war, by a strong hand and an outstretched arm, and by
great terrors, according to all that Yahweh your God did for you in
Egypt before your eyes? 35 To you it was shown, so that you might
know that Yahweh, he is God; there is no other besides him. 36 From
the sky he let you hear his voice so as to instruct you, and on the
earth he let you see his great fire, and out of that fire you heard his
words. 37 Because he loved your forefathers, he chose their offspring
after them, and he himself, in person[e] and in great strength, brought
you out of Egypt, 38 to drive out ahead of you nations bigger and
stronger than you, to bring you in and hand over their land to you
as your inheritance, as is now happening. 39 Know therefore today,
and lay it to your heart, that Yahweh, he is God in heaven above and
on the earth beneath; there is no other. 40 Keep his statutes and his
commands, which I command you today, so that it may go well with
you and with your children after you, and so that you may prolong
your days in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you for all time."
41 Then Moses set apart three cities beyond the Jordan, toward the
sunrise, 42 so that anyone who killed his neighbor unintentionally,
without having hated him in the past, could flee there, and by fleeing
to one of these cities he might live: 43 Bezer, in the desert on the table-
land, belonged to the Reubenites; Ramoth in Gilead to the Gadites;
and Golan in Bashan to the Manassites.[f]
44 This is the instruction[g] that Moses set before the Israelites. 45 These
are the testimonies, the statutes, and the rulings that Moses spoke to
the Israelites when they came out of Egypt, 46 across the Jordan, in
the valley opposite Beth Peor, in the territory of Sihon, the Amorite

king who ruled from Heshbon, whom Moses and the Israelites had overcome as they were leaving Egypt. 47 They took possession of his land and the land of Og king of Bashan, the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan toward the sunrise, 48 It stretched from Aroer, at the rim of the Arnon gorge, to Mount Sion[h] (that is, Hermon), 49 as well as all the Arabah on the east side of the Jordan down to the Sea of the Arabah, beneath the slopes of Pisgah.

Notes

- a (4:3) Baal-peor means "lord of Peor." See Numbers 25:1–9.
- b (4:13) Hebrew "the ten words," the Ten Commandments (also 10:4). See 5:6–21.
- c (4:32) Or "Adam." Hebrew ʾadam, "humankind," which is also the name of the first man.
- d (4:33) Or "the voice of God." The Septuagint reads "the voice of the living God."
- e (4:37) Hebrew "with his face."
- f (4:43) Bezer means "fortress"; Ramoth means "heights"; Golan may mean "circle" or "exile." Gilead may mean "heap of witness" (Genesis 31:47–48).
- g (4:44) Or "law." Hebrew torah.
- h (4:48) Hebrew Siʾon, a different name from Zion in Jerusalem. The Syriac reads "Sirion" (compare 3:9).

Chapter 5

1 Moses summoned all Israel and said to them: "Listen, Israel, to the statutes and rulings I am announcing in your hearing today. Learn them, and be careful to carry them out. 2 Yahweh our God made a covenant with us at Horeb. 3 Yahweh did not make this covenant with our ancestors, but with us, we who are all of us here alive this day. 4 Face to face Yahweh spoke with you on the mountain, out of the fire. 5 (At that time I was standing between Yahweh and you to relay Yahweh's word to you, since the fire frightened you and you would not climb the mountain.) He said:

6 'I am Yahweh your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house where you were slaves.[ab]

7 'You shall have no other gods before me.[c]

8 'Do not make yourself a carved image, the likeness[d] of anything in the sky overhead, on the earth beneath, or in the water below the earth. 9 Do not bow down to them or worship them, for I, Yahweh your God, am a jealous God, holding children to account for the

wrongdoing of their fathers, to the third and the fourth generation
of those who hate me, 10 yet I show steadfast love[e] for a thousand
generations[f] to those who love me and keep my commands.
11 'You shall not take up the name of Yahweh your God for an empty
purpose,[g] for Yahweh will not hold guiltless whoever takes up his
name for an empty purpose.
12 'Keep the Sabbath day[h] holy by observing it, just as Yahweh your
God commanded you. 13 Six days you are to labor and do all your work,
14 Yet the seventh day is a Sabbath belonging to Yahweh your God.
On it you shall do no work at all: you, your son, your daughter, your
male servant, your female servant, your ox, your donkey, any of your
livestock, or the sojourner living inside your gates; that your male
servant and female servant may rest as well as you. 15 Remember that
you yourself were a slave in the land of Egypt, and that Yahweh your
God brought you out of there by a strong hand and an outstretched
arm. That is why Yahweh your God has commanded you to keep the
Sabbath day.[i]
16 'Honor your father and your mother, as Yahweh your God com-
manded you, so that your days may be long and that it may go well
with you on the soil that Yahweh your God is giving you.[j]
17 'You shall not murder.[k]
18 'And you shall not commit adultery.
19 'And you shall not steal.
20 'And you shall not testify against your neighbor as an empty[l]
witness.
21 'And you shall not covet your neighbor's wife, and you shall not
crave your neighbor's house or field, his slave, male or female, his ox
or donkey, or anything at all that is your neighbor's.'[m]
22 "These are the words Yahweh spoke with a mighty voice to your
whole assembly on the mountain, out of the fire, the cloud, and the
dense darkness, and he said nothing more. He wrote them on two
stone tablets and gave them to me. 23 But when you heard the voice
out of the darkness, while the mountain was ablaze with fire, you
came to me, all the heads of your tribes and your elders, 24 and you
said, 'See, Yahweh our God has shown us his glory and his greatness,

and we heard his voice from the midst of the fire; today we have seen
that God may speak with a person, and that person lives on. 25 But
now, why should we die? This great fire will devour us. If we go on
hearing the voice of Yahweh our God any longer, we will die. 26 For
what mortal[n] has ever heard the living God's voice speak from out
of the fire, as we did, and still lived? 27 You go near and hear all that
Yahweh our God says. Then you tell us everything that Yahweh our
God tells you, and we will hear and do it.'
28 "Yahweh heard what you said to me, and Yahweh said to me, 'I have
heard the words that this people spoke to you. All that they have
spoken is well said. 29 If only their hearts were always set like this, to
fear me and keep all my commands, so that they and their children
might prosper forever! 30 Go and say to them, "Go back to your tents." 31
But you, stand here beside me, and I will tell you the whole command,
the statutes and the rulings, that you shall teach them, so they will
do them in the land I am giving them to possess.' 32 Take care, then,
to act as Yahweh your God has commanded you. Do not turn aside
to the right hand or to the left. 33 Walk in the whole way that Yahweh
your God has commanded you, so that you may live and prosper and
have long life in the land you are going to possess.

Notes

- a (5:6) Verses 6–21 give the Ten Words (4:13) in a form close to Exodus 20:2–17; the main differences are noted at verses 8, 11, 12, 15, 16, 17, 20, and 21. Jewish and Christian traditions divide the Ten Words in different ways; the paragraphing here follows the commands, not any one numbering.
- b (5:6) The Nash Papyrus, a single sheet bought in Egypt and usually dated to the second or first century BC, contains a Hebrew text of the Ten Words followed by the Shema (6:4–5). Before the Dead Sea Scrolls were found, it was the oldest known Hebrew biblical manuscript. Its text of the Ten Words is reported to blend the forms of Exodus 20 and Deuteronomy 5 (for example, it gives the creation reason for the Sabbath found in Exodus 20:11) and to place the command against adultery before the command against murder. These details should be checked against a critical edition.
- c (5:7) Or "besides me" or "in addition to me"; Hebrew "before my face."
- d (5:8) Exodus 20:4 reads "or any likeness"; here the Hebrew has no "or," so the second phrase may explain the first. Some Hebrew manuscripts and ancient versions are reported to read "or" here as well.
- e (5:10) Hebrew hesed, loyal and faithful love, especially within a covenant.

- f (5:10) Or “to thousands.”
- g (5:11) Or “in vain” or “to deceive”; Hebrew “lift up the name … to emptiness.”
- h (5:12) Exodus 20:8 reads “Remember the Sabbath day.” Sabbath means “ceasing” or “rest.”
- i (5:15) In Exodus 20:11 the reason given for the Sabbath is that Yahweh rested on the seventh day of creation. Here the reason is Israel’s release from slavery, and verse 14 adds the ox, the donkey, and the rest for slaves.
- j (5:16) The words “as Yahweh your God commanded you” and “that it may go well with you” are not in Exodus 20:12.
- k (5:17) Hebrew ratsah, the unlawful killing of a person. In verses 18–21 the Hebrew joins each command to the one before it with “and,” which Exodus 20 does not.
- l (5:20) Hebrew shaw’, “empty” or “worthless”; Exodus 20:16 has sheqer, “false.”
- m (5:21) Exodus 20:17 puts the neighbor’s house first and uses the same verb, “covet” (Hebrew hamad), for both clauses. Here the wife comes first, a second verb (hit’awweh, “crave” or “desire”) is used for the house and property, and “his field” is added. The Septuagint also has “his field.”
- n (5:26) Hebrew “who of all flesh,” that is, what mortal.

Chapter 6

1 “Now this is the command—the statutes and the rulings—that
Yahweh your God directed me to teach you, for you to carry out in the
land you are crossing over to possess, 2 so that all your life you may
revere Yahweh your God and observe all his statutes and command-
ments, which I am giving you—you, your son, and your grandson
—in order that you may live long. 3 Listen, then, Israel, and take care
to obey, so that you may prosper and become very numerous in a
land flowing with milk and honey, just as Yahweh, the God of your
forefathers, has promised you.[a]
4 “Hear,[b] Israel: Yahweh is our God; Yahweh is one.[c] 5 You shall love
Yahweh your God with all your heart,[d] with all your soul,[e] and with
all your strength.[f] 6 These words that I am commanding you today
are to stay on your heart. 7 Impress them on your children. Talk about
them when you are sitting at home and when you are out on the road,
when you lie down and when you get up. 8 Bind them as a sign on
your hand, and let them be a headband[g] between your eyes. 9 Inscribe
them on the doorframes[h] of your house and on your city gates.

10 “Yahweh your God will bring you into the land that he swore to give
you when he made his oath to your forefathers, Abraham, Isaac, and
Jacob—a land with great and splendid cities that you did not build,
11 houses packed with all kinds of good things that you did not put
there, cisterns you never dug, vineyards and olive trees you never
planted. When you have eaten your fill, 12 be on your guard so that
you do not forget Yahweh, who brought you out of the land of Egypt,
out of the house of slavery. 13 Fear Yahweh your God, serve him, and
take your oaths in his name. 14 Do not go after other gods, gods of
the peoples who are all around you, 15 for Yahweh your God, who
is in your midst, is a jealous God. Otherwise the anger of Yahweh
your God will flare up against you, and he will sweep you off the face
of the ground. 16 Do not test Yahweh your God the way you tested
him at Massah.[i] 17 Be sure to keep the commands of Yahweh your
God, and the testimonies and statutes he has laid on you. 18 Do what
is upright and good in Yahweh’s sight, so that things may go well
for you, and so that you may enter and take over the good land that
Yahweh promised on oath to your forefathers, 19 by pushing all your
enemies out of your way, as Yahweh has said.
20 “In days to come, when your son asks you, ‘What is the meaning
of the testimonies, the statutes, and the rulings that Yahweh our God
has commanded you?’ 21 tell your son, ‘Pharaoh made slaves of us
in Egypt, and Yahweh brought us out of Egypt with a strong hand.
22 Yahweh did signs and wonders, great and terrible, against Egypt,
against Pharaoh, and against his entire household, while we watched.
23 But us he brought out from there, so that he might bring us in
and give us the land that he had sworn to our forefathers. 24 Yahweh
commanded us to perform all these statutes and to fear Yahweh our
God, for our own good at all times, so that he might keep us alive, as
he has to this day. 25 And it will count as righteousness for us if we
take care to keep this whole command in the presence of Yahweh our
God, as he has commanded us.’

Notes

- a (6:3) The Septuagint adds at the end of the verse, “and these are the ordinances and the judgments which the Lord commanded the children of Israel in the

wilderness, when they had gone forth from the land of Egypt" (Brenton). The Nash Papyrus (see 5:6) is reported to have a similar heading before the Shema.

- b (6:4) Hebrew shemaʿ, "hear" or "listen and obey." From this word, verses 4–9 are known in Jewish tradition as the Shema. In many Hebrew manuscripts the last letter of "Hear" and the last letter of "one" are written large.
- c (6:4) Or "Yahweh our God, Yahweh is one," or "Yahweh our God is one Yahweh," or "Yahweh is our God, Yahweh alone." The Hebrew has four words after "Israel," literally "Yahweh our-God Yahweh one," with no verb. "One" may stress that Yahweh is undivided and unique, or that Israel is to worship Yahweh alone. The Septuagint reads "The Lord our God is one Lord," the form quoted in Mark 12:29. The Nash Papyrus (see 5:6) contains this verse; it is reported to differ slightly from the Hebrew text used here.
- d (6:5) Hebrew lebab, the center of thought, will, and feeling. The Septuagint has "mind."
- e (6:5) Or "your whole being" or "your life."
- f (6:5) Hebrew meʾod, literally "muchness," that is, all your power and resources.
- g (6:8) Hebrew totaphot, a word of uncertain meaning. Later Jewish practice understood this verse to refer to tefillin, small boxes containing these words, worn on the arm and forehead.
- h (6:9) Hebrew mezuzot, from which comes the name mezuzah for the small case with these words fixed to a doorpost.
- i (6:16) Massah means "testing" (Exodus 17:7).

Chapter 7

1 "When Yahweh your God brings you into the land you are entering
to possess, he will clear away many nations ahead of you—the Hittite
and the Girgashite, the Amorite and the Canaanite, the Perizzite, the
Hivite, and the Jebusite, seven nations more numerous and powerful
than you. 2 When Yahweh your God hands them over to you and you
strike them down, you must devote them to destruction. Make no
covenant with them, and do not be merciful to them. 3 Do not marry
among them. Do not give your daughter to his son, and do not take
his daughter for your son, 4 because he would lead your son away
from following me, and they would serve other gods. Then Yahweh's
anger would blaze against you, and he would destroy you quickly.
5 Rather, this is what you are to do to them: pull down their altars,
shatter their standing stones, hack down their Asherah poles,[a] and
burn their carved images. 6 For you are a people holy to Yahweh your
God. Out of all the peoples on the face of the earth, Yahweh your

God has chosen you to be a people that is his treasured possession.
7 Yahweh did not become attached to you and select you because
your numbers exceeded those of the other peoples—indeed you were
the smallest of all peoples— 8 It was because Yahweh loved you, and
because he was keeping the oath he had sworn to your forefathers,
that Yahweh brought you out with a strong hand and ransomed you
from the house of slavery, out of the grip of Pharaoh, king of Egypt.
9 Know therefore that Yahweh your God, he is God, the faithful God,
keeping covenant and loyal love to a thousand generations of those
who love him and keep his commandments, 10 and who pays back
those who hate him to their faces, destroying them. With the one
who hates him he will not delay; he will pay him back to his face. 11
So keep the command, the statutes, and the rulings that I am giving
you today, and carry them out.
12 "Because you listen to these rulings and keep them and act on them,
Yahweh your God will keep with you the covenant and the steadfast
love he swore to your forefathers. 13 and he will love you, bless you,
and multiply you; he will bless the fruit of your womb and the fruit
of your ground, your grain, your new wine, and your oil, the increase
of your herd and the young of your flock, in the land that he swore to
your ancestors to give you. 14 You will be blessed beyond every other
people. No man or woman among you will be childless, and none of
your livestock will be barren. 15 Yahweh will turn every sickness away
from you. He will not bring on you any of the dreadful diseases of
Egypt that you know about; he will put them on all who hate you
instead. 16 And you shall consume all the peoples whom Yahweh your
God is giving over to you; your eye shall not spare them, nor shall
you serve their gods, for that will be a snare to you.
17 "You may think to yourself, 'These nations outnumber me. How can
I drive them out?' 18 But do not be afraid of them. Call to mind what
Yahweh your God did to Pharaoh and all Egypt: 19 the great ordeals
your eyes witnessed, the signs and the wonders, the strong hand
and the outstretched arm by which Yahweh your God brought you
out. Yahweh your God will do just the same to all the peoples you
are afraid of. 20 Yahweh your God will also send the hornet[b] against

them, until even the survivors who hide from you have perished. 21 Do not tremble before them, for Yahweh your God is in your midst, a God great and awe-inspiring. 22 Yahweh your God will clear these nations away before you a little at a time. You will not be allowed to finish them off all at once, or the wild beasts would become too many for you. 23 Yahweh your God will deliver them up to you and throw them into great panic until they are wiped out. 24 He will hand their kings over to you, and you will blot out their names from under the heavens. No one will be able to hold his ground against you until you have destroyed them. 25 You shall burn the images of their gods in the fire. Do not desire the silver and the gold that covers them, and do not take it for yourself, or it will be a trap for you, for it is an abomination[c] to Yahweh your God. 26 Do not bring an abomination into your house, or you will become devoted to destruction as it is. You must regard it as vile and detest it, for it is devoted to destruction.

Notes

- a (7:5) Wooden poles or trees associated with the goddess Asherah.
- b (7:20) Or "panic" or "plague"; the meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain. The Septuagint has "hornets."
- c (7:25) Hebrew to'ebah, something detestable or abhorrent, especially in worship.

Chapter 8

1 "Every command that I give you today you must take care to carry out, so that you may live and grow numerous and go in and possess the land Yahweh swore to your forefathers. 2 And remember the entire journey on which Yahweh your God has led you for forty years in the wilderness, to humble you, putting you to the test in order to learn what was in your heart, whether or not you would observe his commandments. 3 He humbled you, let you go hungry, and then fed you with manna,[a] which neither you nor your forefathers had ever known, so that he might teach you that people do not live on bread alone; rather, people live on every word that comes from Yahweh's mouth. 4 Your clothes did not wear out on your backs, and your feet did not swell, all these forty years. 5 Know then in your heart that Yahweh your God disciplines you just as a man disciplines his son. 6 Keep the commands of Yahweh your God, walking in his ways and

fearing him. 7 For Yahweh your God is bringing you into a good land,
a land of flowing streams, of springs and underground waters that
well up in the valleys and in the hills, 8 a land of wheat and barley,
of vines and figs and pomegranates, a land of olive oil and honey,[b]
9 a land where you will never be short of bread to eat and will lack
nothing, a land whose rocks contain iron and from whose hills you
can mine copper. 10 You will eat until you are full, and you will bless
Yahweh your God for the good land he has given you.
11 "Be careful not to forget Yahweh your God by neglecting his
commands, his rulings, and his statutes, which I am commanding
you today. 12 When you have eaten all you want and have built good
houses and are living in them, 13 when your cattle and sheep have
multiplied, your silver and gold have increased, and all that you own
has grown, 14 do not let your heart become proud so that you forget
Yahweh your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out
of the house of slavery. 15 He led you through the vast and dreadful
wilderness, a land of burning[c] serpents and scorpions, of parched
ground with no water. He brought water out of hard rock for you.
16 He fed you manna in the wilderness, something your forefathers
had never known, to humble you and put you to the test, so that in
the end he might do you good. 17 Do not say to yourself, 'My own
strength and the power of my own hand have won me this wealth.' 18
Remember Yahweh your God, for it is he who gives you the power to
gain wealth, so that he may establish his covenant that he swore to
your forefathers, as he is doing today. 19 But if you do forget Yahweh
your God and follow other gods and serve them and bow down to
them, I warn you solemnly today that you will certainly perish. 20 Like
the nations that Yahweh is wiping out before you, so you too will
perish, because you would not obey the voice of Yahweh your God.

Notes

- a (8:3) Manna is probably named from the question "What is it?" (Exodus 16:15).
- b (8:8) Probably both bees' honey and the thick syrup made from dates or grapes.
- c (8:15) Hebrew saraph, "burning," perhaps from the painful bite of these snakes (Numbers 21:6).

Chapter 9

1 “Hear, Israel: today you are about to cross the Jordan to go in and
dispossess nations bigger and mightier than you, with huge cities
walled up to the sky, 2 a people great and tall, the sons of the
Anakim, whom you know about, and about whom you have heard it
said, ‘Who can make a stand against the sons of Anak?’ 3 Know for
certain today that it is Yahweh your God who will cross over in front
of you, a consuming fire. He will destroy them; he will bring them
down before you, and you will drive them out and make them vanish
quickly, as Yahweh has told you. 4 When Yahweh your God has thrust
them out of your way, do not say to yourself, ‘Yahweh brought me
in to take this land because I am righteous.’ No, it is because these
nations are wicked that Yahweh is driving them out before you. 5 You
are not going in to take their land because of your righteousness or
the uprightness of your heart. It is because of the wickedness of these
nations that Yahweh your God is driving them out before you, and to
keep the promise Yahweh swore to your forefathers, Abraham, Isaac,
and Jacob. 6 Understand, then, that Yahweh your God is not giving
you this good land to possess because of any righteousness of yours,
for you are a stiff-necked people.
7 “Remember, and do not ever forget, how you made Yahweh your
God angry in the wilderness. From the day you left the land of Egypt
until you reached this place, you have been defying Yahweh. 8 At
Horeb too you stirred Yahweh to anger, and his anger against you
was enough to make him destroy you. 9 I had gone up the mountain
to receive the stone tablets, the tablets of the covenant Yahweh had
made with you, and I remained on the mountain forty days and forty
nights without eating bread or drinking water. 10 Yahweh handed me
the two stone tablets, written with the finger of God, and on them
were all the words Yahweh had said to you on the mountain from the
midst of the fire, on the day the people were assembled. 11 It was at the
end of the forty days and forty nights that Yahweh gave me the two
stone tablets, the tablets of the covenant. 12 Then Yahweh said to me,
‘Get up, go down from here at once, for the people you brought out of
Egypt have behaved wickedly; they have been quick to leave the path

I commanded them, and have made for themselves a cast image.’ 13
Yahweh said further to me, ‘I have watched this people, and see what
a stiff-necked people they are! 14 Let me be, so that I may destroy them
and wipe their name out from under the heavens. Then I will make
you into a nation stronger and larger than they are.’ 15 So I turned
and came down from the mountain, and the mountain was burning
with fire, and the two tablets of the covenant were in my two hands.
16 When I looked, there you were: you had sinned against Yahweh
your God. You had made yourselves a calf of cast metal. How quickly
you had left the way Yahweh had commanded you! 17 So I grasped the
two tablets, flung them down out of my hands, and smashed them
before your eyes. 18 Then, as before, I lay face down before Yahweh
forty days and forty nights, eating no bread and drinking no water,
on account of every sin you had committed in doing what was evil
in Yahweh’s sight and provoking him to anger. 19 For I dreaded the
fury and wrath that Yahweh had turned against you, ready to destroy
you. But again Yahweh listened to me that time. 20 With Aaron[a] too
Yahweh was angry enough to destroy him, so I prayed for Aaron also
at that time. 21 As for that sinful thing you had made, the calf, I took
it and burned it up. I beat it to pieces and ground it down until it was
fine as dust, and I threw the dust into the brook that runs down the
mountain.
22 “At Taberah,[b] at Massah, and at Kibroth-hattaavah[c] you angered
Yahweh again. 23 And when Yahweh sent you out from Kadesh-barnea
with the words, ‘Go up and possess the land I have given you,’ you
defied the command of Yahweh your God. You put no trust in him
and did not listen to his voice. 24 You have been rebels against Yahweh
ever since I have known you.[d]
25 “So I lay face down before Yahweh for those forty days and forty
nights, because Yahweh had said he would destroy you. 26 I prayed
to Yahweh: ‘Lord Yahweh, do not destroy your people, your own
inheritance, whom you ransomed by your greatness and brought out
of Egypt with a strong hand. 27 Remember your servants Abraham,
Isaac, and Jacob. Pay no attention to how stubborn this people is, to
their wickedness or their sin, 28 lest the land from which you brought

us out say, “Because Yahweh was not able to bring them into the land that he had promised them, and because he hated them, he has brought them out to kill them in the wilderness.” 29 But they are your own people and your inheritance, brought out by your great power and your outstretched arm.’

Notes

- a (9:20) The meaning of Aaron’s name is uncertain; it may be of Egyptian origin.
- b (9:22) Taberah means “burning” (Numbers 11:1–3).
- c (9:22) Kibroth-hattaavah means “graves of craving” (Numbers 11:34).
- d (9:24) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint reads “from the day in which he became known to you” (Brenton), and the Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to have a similar reading.

Chapter 10

1 “At that time Yahweh said to me, ‘Carve out two stone tablets like the first pair and climb up to me on the mountain. Make yourself a wooden chest[a] too. 2 I will write on the tablets the words that were on the first tablets, which you smashed, and you are to place them in the chest.’ 3 So I made a chest of acacia wood and carved two stone tablets like the first ones, and I went up the mountain holding the two tablets. 4 He wrote on the tablets, as he had written the first time, the Ten Words that Yahweh had spoken to you on the mountain out of the fire on the day of the assembly, and Yahweh gave them to me. 5 Then I turned, went back down the mountain, and put the tablets in the chest I had made. There they have remained, as Yahweh commanded me. 6 (The Israelites traveled from Beeroth Bene-jaakan[b] to Moserah.[c] Aaron died there and was buried there, and his son Eleazar[d] became priest in his place. 7 From there they traveled to Gudgodah, and from Gudgodah to Jotbathah, a land with streams of running water.[e] 8 At that time Yahweh set the tribe of Levi[f] apart to carry the ark of Yahweh’s covenant, to stand in Yahweh’s presence and minister to him, and to bless in his name, which they do to this day. 9 This is why Levi has no portion or inheritance among his brothers. Yahweh himself is his inheritance, just as Yahweh your God told him.) 10 “I stayed on the mountain forty days and forty nights, as I had the first time. And Yahweh listened to me that time too; Yahweh chose not

to destroy you. 11 Yahweh told me, ‘Get up and lead the people on
their journey, so that they may go in and take possession of the land
I swore to their forefathers to give them.’
12 “So now, Israel, what does Yahweh your God require of you? Only
this: to fear Yahweh your God, to walk in all his ways and love him, to
serve Yahweh your God with all your heart and all your soul, 13 and to
keep the commands and statutes of Yahweh that I give you today, for
your own good. 14 Look: to Yahweh your God belong the heavens, even
the highest heavens, and the earth with all that is in it. 15 Yet Yahweh
took delight in your forefathers and loved them, and he chose you,
their descendants after them, from all the peoples, as you see today.
16 So circumcise your hearts,[g] and stop being stubborn. 17 For Yahweh
your God is God over all gods and Lord over all lords, the great
God, mighty and awe-inspiring, who plays no favorites and takes no
bribes. 18 He upholds the cause of the fatherless and the widow, and he
loves the foreigner, providing him with food and clothing. 19 You also
must love the foreigner, for you were once foreigners in the land of
Egypt. 20 Fear Yahweh your God and serve him. Hold fast to him, and
swear your oaths by his name. 21 He is the one you praise; he is your
God, who has done for you these great and fearsome things that you
have seen with your own eyes. 22 When your forefathers went down
to Egypt, they were seventy persons, and now Yahweh your God has
made you as numerous as the stars of the sky.

Notes

- a (10:1) Hebrew ʾaron, “chest,” the word used for the ark of the covenant (verse 8).
- b (10:6) Beeroth Bene-jaakan means “wells of the sons of Jaakan.” The Septuagint reads “Beeroth of the sons of Jakim.”
- c (10:6) Moserah may mean “chastening.” Numbers 33:30–38 lists these stopping places in a different order and places Aaron’s death at Mount Hor.
- d (10:6) Eleazar means “God has helped.”
- e (10:7) Gudgodah may mean “cleft”; Jotbathah means “pleasantness.” The Septuagint spells them Gadgad and Etebatha.
- f (10:8) Levi probably means “joined” or “attached” (Genesis 29:34).
- g (10:16) Hebrew “circumcise the foreskin of your hearts.”

Chapter 11

1 “Love Yahweh your God, and always keep what he requires: his
statutes, his rulings, and his commands. 2 Consider today—for it is not
your children I am speaking to, who have not known or seen it—the
discipline of Yahweh your God, his greatness, his mighty hand and
outstretched arm, 3 the signs and the deeds he performed in Egypt
against Pharaoh king of Egypt and his whole country, 4 and what
he did to the Egyptian army, its horses and chariots, in making the
waters of the Red Sea flow over them while they were chasing you,
so that Yahweh annihilated them to this very day; 5 what he did for
you in the wilderness until you arrived here, 6 and what he did to
Dathan and Abiram,[a] the sons of Eliab the son of Reuben, how the
earth opened its mouth and swallowed them, their households, their
tents, and every living being in their possession, in the midst of all
Israel. 7 Your own eyes have seen every great deed that Yahweh has
done.

8 “So keep every command I give you today, so that you will be strong
enough to enter and take the land you are crossing over to possess,
9 and so that you may live long in the land Yahweh swore to give to
your forefathers and to their descendants, a land flowing with milk
and honey. 10 For the land you are about to enter and possess is unlike
the land of Egypt, which you left, where you would sow your seed
and water it by foot,[b] as in a vegetable garden. 11 But the land you are
going over to take is a land of hills and valleys, which drinks water
from the rain of heaven, 12 a land Yahweh your God looks after. The
eyes of Yahweh your God are always on it, from the start of the year
to its close.

13 “And if you indeed listen to my commandments that I command
you today, to love Yahweh your God and to serve him with all your
heart and with all your soul, 14 then I[c] will send rain on your land at
the proper time, the autumn rain and the spring rain,[d] and you will
gather in your grain, your new wine, and your oil. 15 I will make grass
grow in your fields for your livestock, and you will eat your fill. 16 Be
on your guard, so that your hearts are not led astray and you turn
away to serve other gods and worship them. 17 Then Yahweh’s anger

would burn against you. He would close up the sky so that no rain falls and the soil gives no harvest, and you would soon disappear from the good land Yahweh is giving you.
18 "Store up these words of mine in your heart and soul. Tie them as a sign on your hand, and let them be a headband between your eyes. 19 Teach them to your children, talking about them as you sit at home and as you travel the road, as you lie down and as you rise. 20 Write them on the doorframes of your house and on your gates, 21 so that you and your children may live many days in the land Yahweh swore to your forefathers to give them, as long as the heavens stand above the earth. 22 For if you will diligently observe this entire commandment which I am giving you to perform—to love Yahweh your God, to walk in all his ways, and to cling to him— 23 then Yahweh will drive out all these nations from before you, and you will dispossess nations greater and mightier than yourselves. 24 Every place your foot steps on will be yours. Your borders will run from the wilderness to Lebanon, and from the River—the Euphrates—to the western sea.[e] 25 No one will be able to stand against you; Yahweh your God will put the dread and fear of you on all the land on which you tread, just as he told you.
26 "Look: today I am placing before you blessing and curse: 27 a blessing if you obey the commands of Yahweh your God that I am giving you today, 28 and a curse if you disobey the commands of Yahweh your God and leave the way I am commanding you today by following other gods you have not known. 29 When Yahweh your God has brought you into the land you are going to possess, you are to proclaim the blessing on Mount Gerizim and the curse on Mount Ebal.[f] 30 These mountains are across the Jordan, are they not, west of the road where the sun sets, in the land of the Canaanites who live in the Arabah, near Gilgal, beside the great trees[g] of Moreh.[h] 31 For you are about to cross the Jordan to go in and take the land Yahweh your God is giving you. When you have taken it and are living in it, 32 be careful to carry out all the statutes and rulings I am setting before you today.

Notes

- a (11:6) Dathan may mean “belonging to a fountain” (uncertain); Abiram means “my father is exalted”; Eliab means “my God is father”; Reuben means “See, a son!” (Genesis 29:32). See Numbers 16.
- b (11:10) Probably by opening and closing small irrigation channels with the foot, or by treading a water wheel.
- c (11:14) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has “he will give,” and other ancient witnesses are reported to agree.
- d (11:14) Hebrew “the early rain and the late rain”: the autumn rains that soften the ground for plowing (about October–November) and the spring rains that fill out the grain (about March–April).
- e (11:24) Hebrew “the sea behind,” the Mediterranean; the Hebrew compass faced east.
- f (11:29) Gerizim and Ebal stand on either side of Shechem; the meanings of their names are uncertain. See 27:11–13.
- g (11:30) Or “oaks” or “terebinths.” The Septuagint has the singular, “by the high oak” (Brenton).
- h (11:30) Moreh means “teacher.” Gilgal means “circle,” perhaps of stones.

Chapter 12

1 “These are the statutes and ordinances that you shall be careful
to observe in the land that Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, has
given you to possess, as long as you live upon the earth. 2 Utterly
destroy every place where the nations you are dispossessing served
their gods, on the lofty mountains, on the hills, and beneath every
green tree. 3 Tear down their altars, shatter their standing stones, burn
their Asherah poles, cut to pieces the carved images of their gods, and
erase their names from that place. 4 You must not worship Yahweh
your God in the way they worship. 5 Instead, you shall seek the place
that Yahweh your God will choose out of all your tribes to set his
name there as his dwelling,[a] and there you shall go. 6 There you are
to bring your burnt offerings and your sacrifices, your tithes and the
contributions of your hand,[b] your vowed offerings and your freewill
offerings, and the firstborn of your cattle and your flocks. 7 There, in
the presence of Yahweh your God, you and your households shall eat
and be glad in all that you have set your hand to, because Yahweh
your God has blessed you.
8 “You must not act as we are acting here today, where everyone does
whatever he himself thinks right, 9 for you have not yet reached the

rest and the inheritance that Yahweh your God is giving you. 10 But when you cross the Jordan and live in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance, and he gives you rest from all your enemies around you, so that you live in safety, 11 Then, to the place that Yahweh your God chooses for his name to dwell, you shall bring all that I command you: your burnt offerings and your sacrifices, your tithes and the contributions of your hand, and all your finest vowed offerings that you vow to Yahweh. 12 There you shall rejoice before Yahweh your God, along with your sons and daughters and the slaves who serve you, men and women, and with the Levite who lives inside your gates, since no share or inheritance of land has been given him among you. 13 Be careful not to offer up your burnt offerings in just any place you see. 14 Only in the place that Yahweh chooses within one of your tribes shall you offer your burnt offerings, and there you shall do all that I command you.

15 "Nevertheless, whenever you wish, you may slaughter animals and eat meat in any of your towns, according to the blessing that Yahweh your God has given you. Both the unclean and the clean may eat of it, just as they eat gazelle or deer. 16 Only the blood you are not to eat; let it run out onto the ground like water. 17 Within your towns you may not eat the tithe of your grain, your new wine, or your oil, nor the firstborn of your cattle or your flock, nor any of your vowed offerings that you vow, your freewill offerings, or the contributions of your hand. 18 Instead, you shall eat these before Yahweh your God in the place Yahweh your God chooses—you and your children, the slaves who serve you, men and women, and the Levite in your towns—and you shall rejoice before Yahweh your God in every task you undertake. 19 Take care never to abandon the Levite, for as long as you live on your land.

20 "When Yahweh your God widens your borders, as he has promised you, and you say, 'I want to eat meat,' because you long for meat, then eat meat whenever you like. 21 If the place where Yahweh your God chooses to put his name is far away from you, you may slaughter animals from the cattle and sheep Yahweh has given you, in the way I have commanded you, and you may eat them in your own towns

whenever you wish. 22 You may eat it just as gazelle or deer is eaten;
both the unclean and the clean may eat of it. 23 But hold firm: the
blood is not to be eaten, for the blood is the life, and the life must
not be eaten together with the flesh. 24 Do not eat it; pour it out on
the ground like water. 25 Do not eat it, so that things may go well
for you and for your children after you, as you do what is right in
Yahweh's sight. 26 But the holy offerings that are due from you, and
your vowed offerings, you shall take with you to the place Yahweh
chooses. 27 Present your burnt offerings, both the flesh and the blood,
on the altar of Yahweh your God. As for your other sacrifices, their
blood is poured out at the side of the altar of Yahweh your God, while
the flesh you may eat. 28 Listen to all these words I am commanding
you and keep them, so that it may go well with you and with your
children after you for all time, as you do what is good and right in
the sight of Yahweh your God.
29 "When Yahweh your God has cut off before you the nations whose
land you are entering to take, and you have dispossessed them and are
living in their land, 30 take care that you are not lured into following
their ways once they have been wiped out before you. Do not go
asking about their gods, 'In what way did these nations serve their
gods? I will copy them.' 31 You must not do that for Yahweh your God,
for they have done for their gods every detestable thing that Yahweh
hates. They even burn their sons and daughters in the fire as offerings
to their gods.
32 "Whatever I command you, be careful to do it. You must neither add
to it nor subtract from it.[c]

Notes

- a (12:5) Or "to put his name there, to make it dwell." The Hebrew can be read either way.
- b (12:6) Hebrew terumah, a portion "lifted" or set apart from one's goods as an offering.
- c (12:32) Verse 32 is 13:1 in the Hebrew text.

Chapter 13

1 "Suppose a prophet or someone who has dreams appears among you
and announces to you a sign or a wonder,[a] 2 and the sign or wonder he

told you about takes place, and he says, ‘Let us follow other gods’—
gods you have not known—‘and let us serve them.’ 3 You must not
listen to the words of that prophet or that dreamer of dreams, for
Yahweh your God is testing you, to find out whether you love Yahweh
your God with all your heart and with all your soul. 4 It is Yahweh
your God whom you must follow, and him you must fear. Keep his
commands and listen to his voice; serve him and cling to him. 5 As
for that prophet or dreamer of dreams, he is to be put to death, for he
preached revolt against Yahweh your God, who brought you out of
Egypt’s land and ransomed you from the house of slavery, trying to
lead you away from the path Yahweh your God commanded you to
follow. In this way you shall cleanse out the evil from among you.
6 “Suppose your brother, the son of your own mother, or your son or
your daughter, or the wife you hold in your arms, or the friend who
is like your own self, secretly tries to entice you, saying, ‘Come, let us
go and serve other gods’—gods that neither you nor your forefathers
have known, 7 gods of the surrounding peoples, whether they live
close by or far off, from one edge of the earth to the other— 8 do not
yield to him or listen to him. Have no pity on him; do not spare him
or cover for him. 9 Instead, you must surely kill him. Your own hand
must be the first raised against him to put him to death, and after
that the hands of all the people. 10 Stone him with stones until he
dies, because he tried to turn you away from Yahweh your God, who
brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery. 11
Then all Israel will hear of it and fear, and never again will anyone
among you do such wickedness.
12 “Suppose you hear that in one of the towns Yahweh your God is
giving you to live in, 13 some worthless men[b] have come out from
among you and have led astray the people of their town, saying, ‘Let
us go and serve other gods,’ gods you have not known. 14 Then you
must investigate, examine, and inquire carefully. If the report proves
true and the thing is established, that this abominable deed has been
committed in your midst, 15 you must put the people of that town to
the sword, devoting it to destruction with all that is in it, its cattle
included, by the sword. 16 Gather all its plunder into the middle of the

town square, and burn the town and all its plunder in the fire as a whole offering[c] to Yahweh your God. It shall remain a heap of ruins forever and never be built again. 17 Nothing from the devoted things shall stick to your hand, in order that Yahweh may turn from the fierceness of his anger and grant you mercy, and have compassion on you and multiply you, as he swore to your ancestors, 18 because you listen to the voice of Yahweh your God, keeping all his commands that I give you today, and doing what is right in the sight of Yahweh your God.

Notes

- a (13:1) Verses 1–18 are numbered 2–19 in the Hebrew text.
- b (13:13) Hebrew "sons of Belial," an expression of uncertain origin for worthless or wicked people.
- c (13:16) Hebrew kalil, "complete," a word used for an offering that is entirely burned.

Chapter 14

1 "You are the children of Yahweh your God. You must not gash yourselves or make yourselves bald on your foreheads[a] on account of the dead, 2 for you are a people holy to Yahweh your God. Yahweh has chosen you out of all the peoples on the face of the earth to be his own people, his treasured possession.

3 "Do not eat anything abominable. 4 These are the animals you may eat: cattle, sheep, and goats, 5 the deer, the gazelle, the roebuck, the wild goat, the ibex, the antelope, and the mountain sheep.[b] 6 Any animal that has a split hoof, divided into two parts, and that chews the cud, among the animals, you may eat. 7 However, among those that chew the cud or have a divided and split hoof, you must not eat these: the camel, the hare, and the rock badger.[c] They chew the cud, yet their hoof is not split; they are unclean for you. 8 And the pig, because it has a split hoof but does not chew the cud, is unclean for you. You must not eat their flesh or touch their dead bodies.

9 "Among all the creatures living in the water, these you may eat: any with fins and scales may be eaten. 10 But whatever does not have fins and scales you must not eat; it is unclean for you.

11 “Every clean bird you may eat. 12 These, however, you must not
eat: the eagle,[d] the bearded vulture, and the black vulture, 13 the red
kite, the falcon, and every kind of kite,[e] 14 every kind of raven, 15 the
ostrich, the nighthawk, the gull, and every kind of hawk, 16 the little
owl, the great owl, the white owl, 17 the pelican, the carrion vulture,
the cormorant, 18 the stork, every kind of heron, the hoopoe, and the
bat. 19 Every winged insect that swarms is unclean for you; it must
not be eaten. 20 You may eat any clean winged creature.
21 “You shall not eat any carcass; you may give it to the resident alien
in your gates, that he may eat it, or you may sell it to a foreigner; for
you are a holy people to Yahweh your God. You shall not cook a kid
in its mother’s milk.
22 “Be sure to give a tenth of all the yield of your seed, which the field
produces year by year. 23 Before Yahweh your God, in the place where
he chooses to settle his name, you are to eat the tithe of your grain,
your new wine, and your oil, along with the firstborn of your herds
and flocks, that you may learn always to revere Yahweh your God. 24
But if the distance is too great for you, so that you cannot carry the
tithe, because the place where Yahweh your God chooses to put his
name is too far from you, when Yahweh your God has blessed you,
25 then exchange it for silver. Tie up the silver, take it in your hand,
and go to the place Yahweh your God chooses. 26 Spend the silver on
anything you wish: cattle, sheep, wine, beer, or whatever you desire.
Then eat there in the presence of Yahweh your God and celebrate,
you and your household together. 27 And as for the Levite who lives in
your towns, do not abandon him, for he has no portion or inheritance
of his own among you.
28 “At the end of every third year, bring out the whole tithe of your
harvest for that year and store it up in your towns. 29 And the Levite,
because he has no portion or inheritance with you, and the resident
alien, the orphan, and the widow in your towns, shall come and eat
and be satisfied, that Yahweh your God may bless you in all the work
of your hand that you do.

Notes

- a (14:1) Hebrew “make a baldness between your eyes.”

- b (14:5) The identification of several of the animals in this verse is uncertain.
- c (14:7) Hebrew shaphan, the rock hyrax.
- d (14:12) Or "griffon vulture." Many of the birds in verses 12–18 cannot be identified with certainty.
- e (14:13) Hebrew lists three birds here, the second and third written with similar letters; Leviticus 11:14 has only two, and the Septuagint and other ancient witnesses are reported to differ in this list.

Chapter 15

1 "At the end of every seven years you shall grant a release.[a] 2 This
is the manner of the release: every creditor is to let go of the claim
on what he has lent to his neighbor. He must not demand repayment
from his neighbor, his brother, because a release has been proclaimed
in Yahweh's honor. 3 You may demand payment from a foreigner, but
whatever is owed to you by your brother you must let go. 4 There
should, however, be no one in need among you, because Yahweh will
surely bless you in the land Yahweh your God is giving you as an
inheritance to possess, 5 if only you will listen closely to the voice of
Yahweh your God and take care to keep this whole command that
I am giving you today. 6 For Yahweh your God will bless you as he
promised; you will make loans to many nations without borrowing,
and you will govern many nations while none governs you.
7 "If anyone among you is in need, one of your brothers, in any town
of the land Yahweh your God is giving you, do not harden your heart
against your poor brother or close your hand to him. 8 Instead, open
your hand to him generously, and willingly lend him enough to meet
his need, whatever he lacks. 9 Watch out that no base thought enters
your heart, such as, 'The seventh year, the year of release, is drawing
near,' so that you look on your needy brother with a grudging eye
and give him nothing. He may then cry out to Yahweh against you,
and you will be guilty of sin. 10 Give to him freely, and do not give
with a grudging heart, because for this Yahweh your God will bless
you in all your work and in everything you put your hand to. 11 The
poor will never disappear from the land. That is why I command you
to open your hand freely to your brother, to the poor and needy in
your land.

12 “If one of your own people, a Hebrew man or a Hebrew woman, is
sold to you and serves you six years, in the seventh year you must
set him free. 13 And when you set him free, you must not send him off
with nothing. 14 Load him generously with gifts from your flock, your
threshing floor, and your winepress. Give to him in the measure that
Yahweh your God has blessed you. 15 Remember that you were slaves
in the land of Egypt and that Yahweh your God ransomed you. That
is why I am giving you this command today. 16 But if he tells you, ‘I
do not want to leave you,’ because he loves you and your household
and is content with you, 17 then take an awl and push it through his
ear into the door, and he will be your servant for good. You shall treat
your female slave the same way. 18 Do not think it hard to set him
free, because his six years of service to you have been worth twice
the wages of a hired worker. And Yahweh your God will bless you in
everything you do.
19 “You must set apart for Yahweh your God every firstborn male of
your cattle and your flock. Do not put the firstborn of your cattle to
work, and do not shear the firstborn of your sheep. 20 Year by year you
and your household shall eat them in the presence of Yahweh your
God, at the place Yahweh chooses. 21 But if an animal has a defect—if it
is lame or blind, or has any serious blemish—it is not to be sacrificed
to Yahweh your God. 22 You may eat it in your own towns; the unclean
and the clean alike may eat it, as they would a gazelle or a deer. 23
Only you must not eat its blood; pour it out on the ground like water.

Notes

- a (15:1) Hebrew shemittah, a “letting drop,” here the cancellation or suspension of debts.

Chapter 16

1 “Observe the month of Abib (March–April)[a] and keep the Passover
for Yahweh your God, for in the month of Abib Yahweh your God
brought you out of Egypt by night. 2 You shall sacrifice the Passover
animal to Yahweh your God from the flock or the herd, at the place
where Yahweh chooses to make his name dwell. 3 You are not to eat
anything leavened with it. For seven days eat unleavened bread along

with it, the bread of affliction—since you left the land of Egypt in haste
—so that you will recall, as long as you live, the day of your departure
from the land of Egypt. 4 For seven days no leaven is to be found
anywhere in your territory, and none of the meat you sacrifice in the
evening on the first day is to be left over until morning. 5 You are not
allowed to sacrifice the Passover inside any one of the towns Yahweh
your God is giving you, 6 Only at the place where Yahweh your God
chooses to make his name dwell shall you sacrifice the Passover, in
the evening as the sun goes down,[b] at the time of day you came out
of Egypt. 7 You shall cook it and eat it at the place Yahweh your God
chooses, and in the morning you may turn back and go home to your
tents. 8 For six days you shall eat unleavened bread, and the seventh
day shall be a solemn assembly for Yahweh your God. You shall do
no work on it.
9 "Count off seven weeks, starting from the day you first put the sickle
to the standing grain. 10 Then celebrate the Feast of Weeks[c] to Yahweh
your God by bringing a freewill offering from your hand, giving in
proportion to the way Yahweh your God has blessed you. 11 And you
shall rejoice in the presence of Yahweh your God, at the place he
chooses to settle his name: you and your son and daughter, your male
and female servants, the Levite in your gates, and the sojourner, the
orphan, and the widow in your midst. 12 Remember that you were a
slave in Egypt, and take care to keep these statutes.
13 "You shall celebrate the Feast of Booths[d] for seven days, after you
have gathered in the yield of your threshing floor and your winepress.
14 You shall rejoice at your feast—you, your son and daughter, your
male and female servants, and the Levite, the sojourner, the orphan,
and the widow who live in your gates. 15 For seven days you shall hold
the feast for Yahweh your God at the site Yahweh selects; for Yahweh
your God will bless all your harvest and every work of your hands,
and your joy will be complete. 16 Three times a year all your males
are to appear before Yahweh your God at the place he chooses: at the
Feast of Unleavened Bread, at the Feast of Weeks, and at the Feast of
Booths. No one is to appear before Yahweh with empty hands. 17 Each

of you shall bring a gift in keeping with what he can give, according to the blessing that Yahweh your God has given you.
18 "You shall appoint judges and officials in all your towns that Yahweh your God is giving you, tribe by tribe, and they shall judge the people with righteous judgment. 19 You must not pervert justice or show favoritism. Do not accept a bribe, for a bribe blinds the eyes of the wise and twists the words of those who are in the right. 20 Pursue justice, nothing but justice, so that you may live and take possession of the land that Yahweh your God is giving you.
21 "Do not plant any kind of tree as an Asherah pole next to the altar you build for Yahweh your God, 22 and do not set up for yourself a sacred stone, which Yahweh your God hates.

Notes

- a (16:1) Hebrew "the month of Abib" ("ear of grain"), the month when the barley ripened, later called Nisan. It is the first month of the year counted from spring (Exodus 12:2; 13:4). The Hebrew calendar is lunar, so the modern equivalent is approximate.
- b (16:6) Hebrew "in the evening, at the going down of the sun." Exodus 12:6 has the Passover lamb slaughtered "between the two evenings," that is, at twilight.
- c (16:10) Hebrew Shavuot, later also called Pentecost, held seven weeks after Passover, in the third month, Sivan (May–June).
- d (16:13) Or "Tabernacles" (Hebrew Sukkot), held in the seventh month, Tishri (September–October); see Leviticus 23:34.

Chapter 17

1 "You must not sacrifice to Yahweh your God an ox or a sheep that has a blemish or any defect at all, for that is detestable to Yahweh your God.
2 "Suppose there is found among you, in one of the towns Yahweh your God is giving you, a man or woman who does what is evil in the sight of Yahweh your God by breaking his covenant, 3 and has gone and served other gods and bowed down to them, or to the sun or the moon or any of the host of heaven, which I have forbidden, 4 and it is reported to you and you hear of it. Then you shall make a thorough inquiry, and if it is true and the fact is confirmed that this detestable act has been done in Israel, 5 you shall lead out to your town gates the man or the woman guilty of this wicked deed, and that man or

woman shall be stoned until dead. 6 On the evidence of two witnesses
or three witnesses the person who is to die shall be executed; he shall
not be executed on the evidence of one witness. 7 The hands of the
witnesses shall be the first raised against him to put him to death,
and afterward the hands of all the people. So you shall burn away the
evil from your midst.
8 "If any case arises in your towns that is too hard for you—a matter
of bloodshed, of civil rights, or of assault, cases of dispute—then you
shall arise and go up to the place that Yahweh your God chooses. 9 Go
to the Levitical priests and to the judge who holds office in those days.
Consult them, and they will declare to you the verdict. 10 Then you
must act according to the decision they announce to you from that
place that Yahweh chooses. Be careful to do exactly as they instruct
you. 11 Act according to the instruction they teach you and the ruling
they give you. Do not depart from the sentence they pronounce,
either to the right or to the left. 12 Anyone who acts arrogantly and will
not listen to the priest who stands there to minister before Yahweh
your God, or to the judge, that man shall die. So you shall burn away
the evil from Israel. 13 All the people will hear of it and be afraid, and
they will not act presumptuously again.
14 "When you come into the land Yahweh your God is giving you and
have made it yours and are living there, and you say, 'Let me put a
king over myself, like all the surrounding nations,' 15 you may indeed
set over yourself a king whom Yahweh your God chooses. Set as
king over you one from among your own brothers; you may not put
a foreigner over you, one who is not your brother. 16 Only he must
not acquire great numbers of horses for himself, or send the people
back to Egypt to get more horses, since Yahweh has told you, 'You
shall never go back that way again.' 17 He must not take many wives
for himself, or his heart will turn away, and he must not pile up for
himself great amounts of silver and gold. 18 Once he is seated on his
royal throne, he is to copy out for himself on a scroll this law,[a] from
the text in the keeping of the Levitical priests. 19 It shall be with him,
and he shall read in it all the days of his life, so that he may learn to
fear Yahweh his God by keeping all the words of this law and these

statutes and doing them, 20 so that he will not think himself above
his fellow Israelites, nor turn from the commandment to right or left;
then he and his descendants will have a long reign in Israel.

Notes

- a (17:18) The Septuagint renders "a copy of this law" as to deuteronomion touto, "this repetition of the law" (Brenton), literally "this second law," from which the book's English name, Deuteronomy, comes.

Chapter 18

1 "The Levitical priests, the whole tribe of Levi, shall have no share or
inheritance with Israel. They shall live on the food offerings[a] made to
Yahweh, which are his inheritance. 2 They shall have no inheritance
among their brothers; Yahweh himself is their inheritance, as he
promised them. 3 This shall be the priests' due from the people who
offer a sacrifice, whether an ox or a sheep: they shall give the priest
the shoulder, the two cheeks, and the stomach. 4 You shall also give
him the firstfruits of your grain, your new wine, and your oil, and the
first fleece of your sheep. 5 For Yahweh your God has chosen him and
his sons out of all your tribes to stand and minister in the name of
Yahweh for all time.

6 "If a Levite comes from one of your towns anywhere in Israel where
he has been living, and he comes with all the desire of his heart to the
place Yahweh chooses, 7 then he may minister in the name of Yahweh
his God like all his fellow Levites who stand there before Yahweh.
8 He shall receive an equal portion to eat, besides what he receives
from the sale of his family's possessions.[b]

9 "When you enter the land Yahweh your God is giving you, do not
learn to copy the detestable practices of those nations. 10 Let no one be
found among you who makes his son or daughter pass through the
fire, or who practices divination, or tells fortunes, or reads omens, or
is a sorcerer, 11 or casts spells, or consults ghosts or familiar spirits,
or seeks answers from the dead. 12 Whoever does such things is
detestable to Yahweh, and it is because of these detestable things that
Yahweh your God is driving those nations out before you. 13 You must
be blameless before Yahweh your God. 14 For these nations, which you

are about to dispossess, listen to soothsayers and diviners; but as for you, Yahweh your God has not permitted you to do so.
15 "From your own midst, from among your brothers, Yahweh your God will raise up a prophet like me for you. To him you shall listen.
16 This is what you asked of Yahweh your God at Horeb on the day of the assembly, when you said, 'Let us not hear the voice of Yahweh our God again or see this great fire any more, or we will die.' 17 And Yahweh said to me, 'They have spoken well. 18 From among their brothers I will raise up a prophet for them, one like you. My words I will place in his mouth, and he will speak to them all that I command him. 19 And anyone who refuses to listen to my words, which that prophet speaks in my name, I myself will hold accountable. 20 But the prophet who presumes to speak a word in my name that I have not commanded him to speak, or who speaks in the name of other gods, that same prophet shall die.' 21 And if you say in your heart, 'How can we tell which word Yahweh has not spoken?'— 22 If a prophet speaks in Yahweh's name, and the word does not come about or come to pass, that is a word that Yahweh has not spoken; the prophet has spoken it presumptuously; you shall not be afraid of him.

Notes

- a (18:1) Hebrew 'isshe, offerings presented by fire or as food gifts; the exact sense is debated.
- b (18:8) Hebrew obscure; literally "besides his sales according to the fathers."

Chapter 19

1 "When Yahweh your God has cut off the nations whose land he is giving you, and you have driven them out and are living in their cities and houses, 2 you shall set apart three towns for yourselves in the land Yahweh your God is giving you to possess. 3 Prepare the roads, and divide into three parts the territory of the land that Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance, so that anyone who kills a person may flee there. 4 This is the rule for the one who kills someone and flees there to save his life: he must have struck his neighbor unintentionally, without having hated him in the past. 5 For example, a man goes into the forest with his neighbor to cut wood, and as he swings

the axe to fell a tree, the head flies off the handle and strikes his neighbor so that he dies. That man may flee to one of these towns and live. 6 Otherwise the avenger of blood,[a] in hot anger, might pursue the killer and overtake him because the way is long, and strike him dead, though he did not deserve death, since he had not hated his neighbor in the past. 7 That is why I command you to set apart three towns for yourselves. 8 And if Yahweh your God enlarges your territory, as he swore to your forefathers, and gives you all the land he promised to give to your forefathers— 9 provided that you carefully observe this whole commandment that I am giving you today, loving Yahweh your God and walking in his ways at all times—then you shall add three more cities to these three. 10 so that innocent blood may not be shed in the land Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance, and so that bloodguilt may not be on you.

11 "But if a man hates his neighbor and lies in wait for him, attacks him, and strikes him a fatal blow so that he dies, and then flees to one of these towns, 12 the elders of his own town shall send for him, have him brought back from there, and deliver him into the hand of the blood avenger, and he shall die. 13 Show him no pity. You must purge the guilt of innocent blood from Israel, so that it may go well with you.

14 "Do not move your neighbor's boundary marker, set up by those who came before you, in the inheritance you will receive in the land Yahweh your God is giving you to possess.

15 "A single witness shall not be enough to convict a person of any crime or offense that he may have committed. A matter shall be established only on the evidence of two witnesses or of three. 16 If a malicious witness rises up against someone to accuse him of wrongdoing, 17 then both parties to the dispute shall stand before Yahweh, before the priests and the judges who are in office in those days. 18 The judges shall investigate thoroughly, and if the witness turns out to be a false witness who has testified falsely against his brother, 19 then you shall do to him what he had intended to do to his brother. So you shall burn away the evil from your midst. 20 Those who remain will hear and fear, and no one will ever again commit such wickedness

among you. 21 Show no pity: life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot.

Notes

- a (19:6) Hebrew go'el haddam, the relative responsible for avenging a kinsman's death.

Chapter 20

1 "When you go out to war against your enemies and see horses and chariots and an army larger than your own, do not be afraid of them; for Yahweh your God is with you, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt. 2 As you approach the battle, the priest is to step forward and address the troops. 3 He shall say to them, 'Hear, Israel: today you are drawing near to battle against your enemies. Do not lose heart. Do not be afraid, do not panic, and do not tremble before them, 4 for Yahweh your God is the one who goes with you to fight for you against your enemies and to save you.' 5 Then the officers shall say to the people: 'Who is the man that has built a new house but has not yet inaugurated it? Let him return home, or he might die in the battle and another man inaugurate it. 6 And is there anyone who has planted a vineyard but has not yet enjoyed it? Let him go home, lest he die in battle and someone else enjoy it. 7 Has anyone become engaged to a woman and not yet married her? Let him go back to his house, or he may die in the battle and another man marry her.' 8 Then the officers shall say further to the people, 'Is any man fearful and faint of heart? He should return home, lest his fellow soldiers lose courage as he has.' 9 When the officers have finished speaking to the people, commanders of the troops shall be appointed to lead them.

10 "When you draw near to a town to fight against it, first offer it terms of peace. 11 If it answers you peaceably and opens its gates to you, then all the people found in it shall serve you at forced labor. 12 But if it will not make peace with you but makes war against you, then you shall besiege it. 13 And when Yahweh your God delivers it into your hand, you shall put every male in it to the sword. 14 But the women, the children, the animals, and whatever else is in the town, all its plunder, you may seize for yourselves, and you may make use

of what you take from your enemies, which Yahweh your God has given you. 15 That is the way to deal with all the cities far away from you, those that do not belong to the nations nearby. 16 But in the towns of these peoples that Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance, you must not leave alive anything that breathes. 17 You must devote them to complete destruction—the Hittite, the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Perizzite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite[a]—as Yahweh your God has commanded you, 18 so that they will not teach you to do all the detestable things they have done for their gods, and so cause you to sin against Yahweh your God.

19 "When you lay siege to a city for many days, fighting against it to take it, do not ruin its trees by putting an axe to them. Eat their fruit, but do not chop them down. Is the tree of the field a man, that it should come under siege from you?[b] 20 Only the trees you know do not bear fruit you may destroy and cut down, to build siegeworks against the town that is making war with you, until it falls.

Notes

- a (20:17) The Septuagint adds "and the Girgashite" (the Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to agree), making seven nations as in 7:1.
- b (20:19) Or "for the tree of the field is man's life." The Hebrew is difficult.

Chapter 21

1 "Suppose a murdered body is discovered lying in a field in the land Yahweh your God is giving you to possess, and no one knows who struck him down. 2 Your elders and judges shall go out and measure from the body to each of the towns around it. 3 Then the elders of whichever town is closest to the body shall take a young cow that has never been put to work or drawn a load under a yoke. 4 and the elders of that town shall take the heifer to a wadi with flowing water, one that has not been tilled or sown, and there in the wadi they shall break the heifer's neck. 5 Then the priests, the sons of Levi, shall come forward, for Yahweh your God has chosen them to serve him and to give blessings in Yahweh's name, and every lawsuit and case of violence is to be decided by what they say. 6 All the elders of that town nearest the slain man shall wash their hands over the heifer whose

neck was broken in the valley, 7 and they shall testify, ‘Our hands did
not spill this blood, nor did our eyes see it happen. 8 Make atonement,
Yahweh, for your people Israel, whom you have redeemed, and do
not lay the guilt of innocent blood on your people Israel.’ Then the
bloodguilt will be atoned for on their behalf. 9 In this way you will
remove from among you the guilt of innocent blood, by doing what
is upright in Yahweh’s eyes.
10 “When you march out to fight your enemies, and Yahweh your God
hands them over to you and you carry off prisoners, 11 and you see
among the captives a beautiful woman and desire her and take her
as your wife, 12 then you shall bring her home to your house, and she
shall shave her head and trim her nails. 13 and she shall remove her
captive’s garments, and stay in your house and mourn her father and
mother for a whole month; afterward you may go in to her and be
her husband, and she shall be your wife. 14 And if you take no delight
in her, you shall let her go where she pleases; but you shall by no
means sell her for money, nor deal with her as a slave, because you
have dishonored her.
15 “Suppose a man has two wives, one whom he loves and one whom
he does not, and each of them has borne him sons, but the eldest
son was born to the wife who is not loved. 16 then when he gives his
sons their inheritance, he cannot make the son of the favored wife
the firstborn ahead of the son of the disliked wife, who is the actual
firstborn. 17 He must instead recognize the firstborn, the son of the
disliked wife, by giving him a double share of everything he owns;
for he is the first of his vigor, and the right of the firstborn belongs
to him.
18 “If a man has a stubborn and rebellious son who will not obey his
father or his mother, and though they discipline him, he will not listen
to them, 19 then his father and mother shall seize him and take him
out to the elders of his city, to the gate of the place where he lives,
20 They shall tell the elders of the town, ‘Our son here is defiant and
disobedient; he refuses to listen to us. He eats too much and drinks
too much.’ 21 Then all the men of his town shall stone him until he

dies. In this way you will remove the evil from among you, and all Israel will hear of it and fear.
22 “If a man has committed a crime worthy of death and is put to death, and you hang him on a tree, 23 his corpse shall not hang overnight on the tree, but you shall bury it that same day, for a hanged man is accursed of God;[a] you shall not defile your land, which Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance.

Notes

- a (21:23) Or “an insult to God.” Galatians 3:13 quotes this verse in a form close to the Septuagint.

Chapter 22

1 “If you see your brother’s ox or his sheep straying, do not pretend you have not seen them. Be sure to bring them back to your brother. 2 If your brother does not live near you, or you do not know who he is, take the animal home with you and keep it until he comes looking for it; then give it back to him. 3 Do the same with his donkey, with his cloak, and with anything your brother loses and you find. You must not look the other way. 4 If you see your brother’s donkey or his ox fallen on the road, do not turn away from them. You must help him lift them up again.
5 “A woman shall not wear a man’s gear, and a man shall not put on a woman’s garment, for whoever does such things is detestable to Yahweh your God.
6 “If you come across a bird’s nest beside the road, in any tree or on the ground, with fledglings or eggs, and the mother is sitting on the fledglings or the eggs, you shall not take the mother with her young. 7 Let the mother go free, though you may take the young for yourself, so that things may go well with you and you may live long.
8 “When you build a new house, put a parapet around your roof, so that you do not bring bloodguilt on your house if anyone falls from it.
9 “You shall not sow your vineyard with two kinds of seed, lest the whole produce become forfeit,[a] both the seed you have sown and the yield of the vineyard. 10 Do not plow with an ox and a donkey

yoked together. 11 Do not wear cloth woven of wool and linen mixed together.
12 "Make tassels on the four corners of the cloak you wrap around yourself.
13 "Suppose a man marries a woman and goes in to her, and then turns against her, 14 and charges her with shameful conduct and gives her a bad name, saying, 'I married this woman, but when I came near her I found no proof of her virginity.' 15 Then the young woman's father and mother shall bring out the proof of her virginity to the elders of the town at the gate. 16 Her father shall say to the elders, 'I gave my daughter to this man as his wife, and he has turned against her. 17 Now he has accused her of shameful things, claiming, "Your daughter was not a virgin when I found her." Yet here is the evidence that she was.' Then they are to unfold the garment in front of the town's elders. 18 The elders of the town are then to seize the man and discipline him. 19 They shall fine him 2½ pounds of silver[b] and give it to the young woman's father, because he has given a bad name to a virgin of Israel. She shall remain his wife; he may never divorce her as long as he lives. 20 But if the accusation proves true, and the evidence that the girl was a virgin cannot be found, 21 then they shall bring her out to the door of her father's house, and the men of her town shall stone her to death, because she has done a disgraceful thing in Israel by acting as a prostitute in her father's house. So you shall burn away the evil from your midst.
22 "If a man is discovered in bed with another man's wife, both shall die—the man who slept with the woman, and the woman. In this way you shall purge the evil from Israel.
23 "If there is a young woman who is a virgin, pledged to be married to a man, and another man meets her in the town and lies with her, 24 bring the two of them out to that town's gate and stone them until they die—the girl because, though she was inside the town, she raised no cry, and the man because he dishonored the wife of his neighbor. So you shall burn away the evil from your midst. 25 But if it is out in the countryside that the man meets the engaged young woman, and he seizes her and lies with her, then only the man who lay with

her shall die. 26 Do nothing to the girl, for there is no sin in her that
deserves death. It is just as when a man rises against his neighbor
and kills him. 27 For he met her in the open country, and though the
engaged young woman cried out, there was no one to rescue her.
28 "If a man meets a young woman who is a virgin and not pledged
to be married, and he seizes her and lies with her, and they are
discovered, 29 the man who lay with her shall give the young woman's
father 20 ounces of silver,[c] and she shall become his wife, because he
has humbled her. He may never divorce her as long as he lives.
30 "A man shall not take his father's wife, and so uncover the edge of
his father's garment.[d]

Notes

- a (22:9) Hebrew "become holy," that is, forfeited to the sanctuary.
- b (22:19) Hebrew "a hundred of silver," that is, 100 shekels, about 40 ounces or 1.15 kilograms.
- c (22:29) Hebrew "fifty of silver," that is, 50 shekels, about 20 ounces or 575 grams.
- d (22:30) Verse 30 is 23:1 in the Hebrew text. To "uncover the skirt" of the father is to violate his marriage; compare Ruth 3:9.

Chapter 23

1 "No man who has been castrated, whether by crushing or by cutting,
may come into the assembly of Yahweh.[a] 2 No one born of a forbidden
union[b] may come into the assembly of Yahweh; not even his offspring
to the tenth generation may come into Yahweh's assembly. 3 No
Ammonite or Moabite may enter the assembly of Yahweh; even to
the tenth generation none of them may ever enter the assembly of
Yahweh, 4 because they did not meet you with bread and water on
your journey when you came out of Egypt, and because they hired
against you Balaam the son of Beor, from Pethor of Aram Naharaim,[c]
to curse you. 5 Yet Yahweh your God refused to heed Balaam, and
turned the curse into a blessing for you, because Yahweh your God
loved you. 6 As long as you live, never work for their welfare or their
good.
7 "Do not abhor an Edomite, for he is your brother. Do not abhor an
Egyptian, because you lived as a foreigner in his land. 8 Their grand-

children, the third generation born to them, may come into Yahweh's assembly.

9 "When you are encamped against your enemies, guard yourself from everything evil. 10 If any man among you is unclean because of something that happened to him at night, he must go outside the camp; he must not come back into the camp. 11 When evening comes he shall bathe in water, and at sunset he may come back into the camp. 12 Mark out a spot outside the camp to which you can go out for your needs. 13 Among your equipment you shall have a digging tool, and when you squat outside, dig a hole with it and turn back and cover your excrement. 14 For Yahweh your God moves about within your camp, to deliver you and to give up your enemies before you; so your camp must be holy, that he may see nothing indecent among you and turn away from you.

15 "Do not hand back to his master a slave who has escaped from his master to you. 16 Let him live with you, among you, in whatever place he chooses within one of your towns, wherever suits him best. Do not oppress him.

17 "No Israelite woman is to become a shrine prostitute,[d] and no Israelite man is to become one. 18 You shall not bring a prostitute's fee or a dog's[e] payment into the house of Yahweh your God for any vow, for both are an abomination to Yahweh your God.

19 "Do not charge your brother interest, whether on money, food, or anything else that may be lent at interest. 20 You may lend at interest to a foreigner, but to your brother you shall not, that Yahweh your God may bless you in all that you undertake in the land you are entering to possess.

21 "When you make a vow to Yahweh your God, do not be slow to fulfill it, for Yahweh your God will certainly require it of you, and you would be guilty of sin. 22 But if you refrain from making a vow, you will not be guilty of sin. 23 Whatever has passed your lips you must be careful to carry out, just as you freely vowed to Yahweh your God with your own mouth.

24 "When you go into your neighbor's vineyard, you may eat as many grapes as you like, until you are full, but you must not put any in

your basket. 25 When you go into the grain field of your neighbor, you may pick ears by hand, but you must not swing a sickle at his standing grain.

Notes

- a (23:1) Verses 1–25 are numbered 2–26 in the Hebrew text.
- b (23:2) Hebrew mamzer, a term of uncertain meaning, perhaps one born of incest or of a marriage forbidden by the law.
- c (23:4) Aram-naharaim means "Aram of the two rivers," the region of upper Mesopotamia.
- d (23:17) Hebrew qedeshah (feminine) and qadesh (masculine), literally "consecrated one"; the exact practice referred to is debated.
- e (23:18) "Dog" probably refers to a male prostitute.

Chapter 24

1 "Suppose a man marries a woman, and later she does not find favor in his eyes because he has found in her some matter of indecency, so he writes her a document of divorce, hands it to her, and sends her away from his house. 2 After leaving his house, she goes off and marries another man. 3 If the second husband also dislikes her, writes her a certificate of divorce, puts it in her hand, and sends her out of his house, or if the second man who married her dies, 4 then her first husband, who sent her away, may not take her back to be his wife after she has been defiled, for that would be detestable before Yahweh. You must not bring guilt on the land Yahweh your God is giving you as an inheritance.

5 "When a man has newly married, he shall not go out with the army or be assigned any public duty. He shall be free at home for one year to bring joy to the wife he has taken.

6 "No one shall take a pair of millstones, or even the upper millstone, as security for a debt, for that would be taking a person's livelihood[a] as security.

7 "If a man is caught kidnapping one of his brothers from among the Israelites, and treats him as a slave or sells him, that kidnapper shall die. So you shall burn away the evil from your midst.

8 "In cases of a skin disease,[b] be very careful to do everything the Levitical priests instruct you. As I commanded them, so you shall take

care to do. [9] Keep in mind how Yahweh your God dealt with Miriam along the road after you left Egypt.
[10] "If you lend anything at all to your neighbor, you must not enter his house to fetch what he offers as a pledge. [11] Wait outside, and the one who is borrowing from you shall carry the pledge out to you. [12] And if he is a poor man, do not go to sleep with his pledge. [13] Be sure to return the pledge to him at sunset, so that he may sleep in his cloak and bless you. It will be counted as righteousness for you before Yahweh your God.
[14] "Do not exploit a hired worker who is poor and needy, whether he is one of your brothers or one of the foreigners who live in your land within your towns. [15] Give him his wages each day before the sun sets, for he is poor and is counting on it. Otherwise he may cry out against you to Yahweh, and you will be guilty of sin.
[16] "Parents shall not be put to death because of their children, nor children because of their parents; each shall die for his own sin.
[17] "Do not deny justice to the foreigner or the fatherless, and do not take a widow's garment as security. [18] Remember that you were a slave in Egypt and that Yahweh your God ransomed you from there. For this reason I am commanding you to do this.
[19] "When you harvest the grain of your field and overlook a sheaf there, do not turn back for it. Leave it for the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow, so that Yahweh your God may bless you in all the work of your hands. [20] When you beat your olive trees, do not go over the branches a second time. What is left shall be for the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow. [21] When you gather the grapes of your vineyard, do not glean it afterward. What is left shall be for the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow. [22] You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt; therefore I am commanding you to do this.

Notes

- a (24:6) Hebrew "life" (nephesh).
- b (24:8) Hebrew tsaraʿat, traditionally "leprosy," a term covering various skin diseases; see Leviticus 13–14.

Chapter 25

1 “When men have a quarrel and go to law, and the judges hear the
case, they shall declare the innocent man in the right and the guilty
man in the wrong. 2 If the one in the wrong deserves a flogging, the
judge shall have him laid down and flogged in front of him, with as
many lashes as his wrongdoing calls for. 3 Forty blows may be given
him, but no more, or else, if he is beaten with more blows than these,
your brother would be degraded in your sight.
4 “You shall not put a muzzle on the ox as it threshes.
5 “When brothers live together and one of them dies childless, the
widow of the dead man must not marry out of the family to a stranger;
her husband’s brother shall come to her and take her to himself as
his wife, performing the brother-in-law’s duty[a] toward her. 6 The
firstborn son she bears shall stand in the place of the dead brother
and bear his name, so that his name is not erased from Israel. 7 But
if the man has no wish to marry his brother’s wife, she shall go to
the gate, to the elders, and tell them, ‘My husband’s brother declines
to establish a name in Israel for his brother; he is unwilling to do a
brother-in-law’s duty toward me.’ 8 The elders of his town shall then
call for him and talk with him. If he stands firm and says, ‘I have no
desire to marry her,’ 9 then his brother’s widow is to approach him
while the elders watch, draw his sandal from his foot, and spit in his
face. And she shall say, ‘So may it be done to the man who refuses to
build up his brother’s household.’ 10 And in Israel his family shall be
called ‘The House of the Unsandaled.’
11 “When men are fighting with one another, and the wife of one
comes near to rescue her husband from the hand of the man striking
him, and she reaches out and seizes him by his private parts, 12 then
you shall cut off her hand. Show her no pity.
13 “You shall not have two kinds of weights in your bag, one heavy,
one light. 14 Do not keep two different measures in your house, one
larger and one smaller. 15 You shall have a full and honest weight; you
shall have a full and honest measure,[b] so that your days may be long
in the land Yahweh your God is giving you. 16 For everyone who does

such things, everyone who deals dishonestly, is detestable to Yahweh your God.
17 "Remember what Amalek did to you on the road as you were coming out of Egypt, 18 how he met you on the way when you were faint and weary and attacked all the stragglers at your rear. He did not fear God. 19 So when Yahweh your God gives you rest from all the enemies surrounding you in the land he is giving you to inherit and possess, you are to wipe out the memory of Amalek from under heaven. Do not forget.

Notes

- a (25:5) Hebrew yabam, the levirate duty, from Latin levir, "husband's brother."
- b (25:15) Hebrew "ephah," a dry measure of about 3/5 bushel (22 liters), standing here for measures of capacity in general. Verse 14 likewise has "an ephah and an ephah," that is, two different measures.

Chapter 26

1 "Once you have entered the land Yahweh your God is giving you to inherit, have taken possession of it, and are living there, 2 you shall take some of the firstfruits of all the produce of the soil which you gather in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you, and put them in a basket, and go to the site where Yahweh your God chooses to settle his name. 3 You shall go to whoever is priest in those days and say to him, 'Today I declare to Yahweh your God that I have entered the land that Yahweh swore to our ancestors to give us.' 4 Then the priest shall take the basket from your hand and set it down before the altar of Yahweh your God. 5 Then you shall answer in the presence of Yahweh your God, 'My father was a perishing Aramean.[a] He went down into Egypt and sojourned there, few in number; but there he became a great nation, strong and populous. 6 But the Egyptians mistreated us, oppressed us, and imposed harsh slavery on us. 7 Then we cried out to Yahweh, the God of our forefathers, and Yahweh heard our voice and saw our affliction, our toil, and our oppression. 8 And Yahweh brought us out of Egypt with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm, with great terror, with signs and with wonders. 9 He led us into this place and has given us this land, a land flowing with milk and honey. 10 And now, look, I have brought the first of

the fruit of the ground that you, Yahweh, have given me.' Then set it down before Yahweh your God and bow down before Yahweh your God. 11 And you shall rejoice in all the good that Yahweh your God has given to you and to your household, you and the Levite and the foreigner who is among you.
12 "When you have completed the tithing of all your produce in the third year, the year of the tithe, giving it to the Levite, the sojourner, the orphan, and the widow, that they may eat in your gates and be filled, 13 then you shall say in the presence of Yahweh your God, 'I have cleared out of my house the portion that is holy and have handed it over to the Levite, the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow, just as you commanded me. I have not broken or forgotten any of your commands. 14 I have not eaten of it while mourning, nor removed any of it when unclean, nor given any of it for the dead. I have obeyed Yahweh my God; I have done everything you commanded me. 15 Look down from your holy dwelling place, from heaven, and bless your people Israel and the ground you have given us, as you swore to our forefathers, a land flowing with milk and honey.'
16 "This day Yahweh your God commands you to do these statutes and rulings. Be careful to do them with all your heart and with all your soul. 17 Today you have declared that Yahweh is your God, and that you will walk in his ways, keep his statutes, his commands, and his rulings, and obey his voice. 18 And Yahweh has declared today that you are a people belonging to him, his own treasure, just as he told you, and that you are to keep all his commands, 19 and that he will set you high above all the nations he has made, for praise and renown and honor, and that you will be a holy people to Yahweh your God, as he has spoken."

Notes

- a (26:5) Or "a perishing Aramean" or "an Aramean about to perish," probably referring to Jacob. The Septuagint reads "My father abandoned Syria."

Chapter 27

1 Then Moses, together with the elders of Israel, gave the people this charge: "Keep the whole command that I am laying on you today. 2 On

the day you cross the Jordan into the land Yahweh your God is giving you, raise up some great stones and coat them with plaster. 3 When you cross over, inscribe on them every word of this law, so that you may enter the land Yahweh your God is giving you, a land flowing with milk and honey, just as Yahweh, the God of your forefathers, promised you. 4 Once you are across the Jordan, set these stones up on Mount Ebal[a] in keeping with today's command, and plaster them with plaster. 5 Build an altar there to Yahweh your God, an altar of stones on which no iron tool has been swung. 6 Make the altar of Yahweh your God out of whole, unhewn stones, and on it offer up burnt offerings to Yahweh your God. 7 Offer peace offerings there too, and eat them, and celebrate in the presence of Yahweh your God. 8 On the stones write every word of this law, clearly and distinctly."
9 Then Moses and the Levitical priests addressed all Israel: "Be still, Israel, and hear! This day you have become the people of Yahweh your God. 10 Therefore listen to the voice of Yahweh your God, and carry out his commands and his statutes, which I am giving you today."
11 On the same day Moses also commanded the people: 12 "After you have crossed the Jordan, these tribes shall take their stand on Mount Gerizim[b] to bless the people: Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Joseph, and Benjamin. 13 And these shall take their stand on Mount Ebal for the curse: Reuben, Gad, Asher, Zebulun, Dan, and Naphtali. 14 The Levites shall then call out loudly to every man of Israel: 15 'A curse on the man who makes an idol, whether carved or cast in metal, a thing Yahweh abhors, made by a craftsman's hands, and sets it up in a hidden place.' Then all the people shall respond, 'Amen.'[c] 16 'A curse on anyone who dishonors his father or his mother.' And all the people shall say, 'Amen.' 17 'A curse on anyone who shifts his neighbor's boundary stone.' And all the people shall say, 'Amen.' 18 'A curse on anyone who makes a blind man lose his way on the road.' And all the people shall say, 'Amen.' 19 'A curse on anyone who twists the justice due to the foreigner, the orphan, or the widow.' And all the people shall say, 'Amen.' 20 'A curse on anyone who lies with his father's wife, for he has uncovered the edge of his father's garment.' And all the

people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 21 ‘Cursed be anyone who has intercourse with any animal.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 22 ‘A curse on anyone who lies with his sister, his father’s daughter or his mother’s daughter.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 23 ‘A curse on anyone who lies with his mother-in-law.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 24 ‘A curse on anyone who kills his neighbor where no one sees.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 25 ‘A curse on anyone who accepts a bribe to kill an innocent person.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’ 26 ‘A curse on anyone who does not stand by the words of this law and carry them out.’ And all the people shall say, ‘Amen.’

Notes

- a (27:4) The Samaritan Pentateuch is reported to read “Mount Gerizim” here, and some scholars think that reading may be older; this needs further study.
- b (27:12) Gerizim and Ebal are the two mountains on either side of Shechem.
- c (27:15) Amen, “so be it,” “surely.”

Chapter 28

1 “If you listen faithfully to the voice of Yahweh your God, taking care to keep all his commands that I give you today, Yahweh your God will raise you high above every nation on earth. 2 All these blessings will come upon you and catch up with you, if you listen to the voice of Yahweh your God: 3 Blessed will you be in the town, and blessed will you be in the countryside. 4 Blessed will be the children you bear, the crops of your ground, and the offspring of your animals—the increase of your cattle and the young of your sheep. 5 Blessed will be your basket and your kneading bowl. 6 Blessed will you be in your coming in, and blessed in your going out.

7 “Yahweh will cause your enemies who rise against you to be routed before you. They will march out against you by one road and run from you by seven roads. 8 Yahweh will command blessing to be with you in your storehouses and on everything you set your hand to; he will bless you in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you. 9 Yahweh will set you up as his own holy people, just as he swore to you, if you keep the commandments of Yahweh your God and walk in his ways. 10 Then all the peoples of the earth will see that you are called by the name of Yahweh,[a] and they will stand in fear of you. 11 Yahweh will

give you an abundance of good things—in the fruit of your womb, in the young of your livestock, and in the yield of your soil—in the land Yahweh swore to your forefathers to give you. 12 Yahweh will open for you his rich storehouse, the heavens, to send rain on your land in its season and to bless all the work of your hands. You will lend to many nations, and you yourself will borrow from none. 13 Yahweh will make you the head, not the tail; you will be only above, and never beneath, if you obey the commandments of Yahweh your God, which I am commanding you today, to observe and do them, 14 and if you do not turn aside to the right or to the left from any of the words I command you today, to go after other gods and serve them.

15 "But if you will not listen to the voice of Yahweh your God, and are not careful to keep all his commands and statutes that I give you today, then all these curses will come upon you and catch up with you: 16 Cursed will you be in the town, and cursed will you be in the countryside. 17 Cursed will be your basket and your kneading bowl. 18 Cursed shall be your offspring, the produce of your soil, the increase of your herds, and the young of your flocks. 19 Cursed will you be in your coming in, and cursed in your going out.

20 "Yahweh will send against you curse, panic, and frustration in everything you set your hand to do, until you are wiped out and perish swiftly because of the evil of your deeds, because you have abandoned me. 21 Yahweh will make the plague cling to you until he has made an end of you in the land you are entering to possess. 22 Yahweh will strike you with wasting disease, with fever, inflammation, burning heat, and drought,[b] with blight and with mildew. They will hound you until you perish. 23 The sky over your head will be bronze, and the earth beneath you iron. 24 Yahweh will turn the rain of your land into powder and dust; it will come down on you from the sky until you are destroyed.

25 "Yahweh will let you be beaten before your enemies. You will go out against them by one road and flee before them by seven roads, and you will become a horror to all the kingdoms of the earth. 26 Your corpses will be food for every bird of the sky and every beast of the earth, and no one will frighten them away. 27 Yahweh will strike you

with the boils of Egypt, with tumors, with scabs, and with an itch that cannot be cured. 28 Yahweh will strike you with madness, blindness, and confusion of mind. 29 At midday you will feel your way like a blind man in darkness, and your paths will lead nowhere. Day after day you will be oppressed and plundered, and there will be no one to save you. 30 You will pledge yourself to a woman, and another man will lie with her. You will build a house and never dwell in it. You will plant a vineyard and not taste its grapes. 31 Your ox will be slaughtered in front of you, yet none of its meat will reach your mouth. Your donkey will be seized in front of you and never come back. Your sheep will be given to your enemies, and there will be no one to help you. 32 Your sons and daughters will be given to another people while you watch, and your eyes will wear themselves out longing for them all day, but your hand will be powerless. 33 A people you have not known will eat up the fruit of your land and all your labor, and you will be nothing but oppressed and crushed all your days. 34 The sights your eyes see will drive you mad. 35 Yahweh will strike you on the knees and legs with painful boils that cannot be healed, from the sole of your foot to the crown of your head.

36 "Yahweh will bring you and the king you set over yourself to a nation that neither you nor your forefathers have known, and there you will serve other gods, of wood and stone. 37 You will become an object of horror, a proverb, and a byword among all the peoples to which Yahweh will drive you. 38 You will carry much seed out to the field and gather in little, because the locust will devour it. 39 You will plant vineyards and tend them, but you will neither drink the wine nor gather the grapes, because the worm will eat them. 40 Olive trees you will have all through your borders, but there will be no oil for you to rub on yourself, for the olives will fall off unripe. 41 You will father sons and daughters, but they will not remain yours, for they will go into captivity. 42 The whirring locust will take over all your trees and the fruit of your ground. 43 The foreigner who lives among you will climb higher and higher above you, while you sink lower and lower. 44 He will lend to you, but you will not lend to him. He will be the head, and you will be the tail.

45 “All these curses will come upon you, pursuing you and overtaking
you until you are destroyed, because you did not listen to the voice of
Yahweh your God or keep the commands and statutes he gave you.
46 They will be a sign and a wonder upon you and your descendants
forever. 47 Because you did not serve Yahweh your God with joy and
gladness of heart when you had plenty of everything, 48 you will serve
your enemies whom Yahweh sends against you, in hunger and thirst,
in nakedness, and lacking everything. He will put an iron yoke on
your neck until he has destroyed you.
49 Yahweh will raise against you a nation from far off, from the ends of
the earth, swift as an eagle in its dive, a nation that speaks a tongue
you do not understand, 50 a fierce-faced nation that shows no regard
for the old and no mercy to the young. 51 It will eat the young of your
livestock and the yield of your soil until you are destroyed. It will
leave you no grain, new wine, or oil, no calves of your herds or lambs
of your flock, until it has brought you to ruin. 52 It will lay siege to
you in all your towns until the high, fortified walls you trust in come
down throughout your land. It will besiege you in all your towns
throughout the land Yahweh your God has given you. 53 Then, in the
siege and in the distress your enemy brings on you, you will eat the
fruit of your own womb, the flesh of the sons and daughters whom
Yahweh your God has given you. 54 Even the most gentle and refined
man among you will look grudgingly at his brother, at the wife he
embraces, and at the last of his children who remain, 55 refusing to give
any of them the flesh of his children that he is eating, because nothing
else is left to him in the siege and distress your enemy will inflict on
you in all your towns. 56 The tender and delicate woman among you,
so tender and delicate that she would not try to put the sole of her foot
on the ground, will begrudge the husband she cherishes, and her son
and her daughter, 57 and at the afterbirth that comes out from between
her feet and the children she bears, for she will eat them secretly for
lack of anything else, in the siege and distress your enemy will inflict
on you in your towns.
58 “If you do not take care to observe all the words of this law written
in this book, and to revere this glorious and awesome name, Yahweh

your God, [59] then Yahweh will bring extraordinary plagues on you and your descendants, great and lasting plagues, and grievous and lasting illnesses. [60] He will bring upon you again every disease of Egypt that terrified you, and they will hold you fast. [61] Yahweh will also bring on you every sickness and every plague not written in this book of the law, until you are destroyed. [62] Though you were as numerous as the stars in the sky, you will be left few in number, because you did not listen to the voice of Yahweh your God. [63] And just as Yahweh took delight in prospering you and increasing your number, so Yahweh will take delight in bringing you to ruin and destroying you; and you shall be plucked from the land you are entering to possess.
[64] "Yahweh will scatter you among all peoples, from one end of the earth to the other, and there you will serve other gods of wood and stone that neither you nor your forefathers have known. [65] Among those nations you will find no ease, no resting place for the sole of your foot. Instead Yahweh will give you there a trembling heart, failing eyes, and a despairing soul. [66] Your life shall hang in suspense before you; night and day you shall be in terror, with no assurance of your life. [67] At daybreak you will say, 'Would that evening were here!' and at nightfall, 'Would that morning were here!' because of the terror gripping your heart and the things your eyes will see. [68] And Yahweh will return you to Egypt in ships, by the route I told you you would never see again; and there you will be put up for sale to your enemies as male and female slaves, but there will be no buyer."

Notes

- a (28:10) Hebrew "that the name of Yahweh is called over you," an expression of ownership.
- b (28:22) Or "sword," following a different vocalization of the Hebrew.

Chapter 29

[1] These are the words of the covenant Yahweh commanded Moses to make with the Israelites in the land of Moab, in addition to the covenant he made with them at Horeb.[a]
[2] Moses summoned all Israel and said to them: "You have seen everything Yahweh did before your eyes in the land of Egypt to Pharaoh

and all his servants and his whole land— 3 the great trials your eyes
saw, the signs, and those great wonders. 4 Yet even now Yahweh has
not given you a mind that understands, eyes that see, or ears that
hear. 5 I led you forty years in the wilderness. Your clothes did not
wear out on you, and your sandals did not wear out on your feet.
6 You ate no bread and drank no wine or strong drink, so that you
might know that I am Yahweh your God. 7 And when you reached this
place, Sihon king of Heshbon and Og king of Bashan marched out to
meet us in battle, and we struck them down. 8 We seized their land
and handed it over as an inheritance to Reuben, to Gad, and to half
the tribe of Manasseh. 9 Therefore observe the words of this covenant
and do them, that you may succeed in all that you do.
10 "All of you are standing today before Yahweh your God—your
leaders, your tribes, your elders, and your officers, every man of
Israel, 11 your little ones, your wives, and the foreigner in your camp,
from the one who cuts your wood to the one who draws your water
— 12 so that you may enter into the covenant of Yahweh your God,
sealed with an oath, which Yahweh your God is making with you
today, 13 in order to establish you today as his people, and that he may
be your God, as he promised you and as he swore to your forefathers,
to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob. 14 And I am making this covenant
and this oath not only with you, 15 but with those who stand here with
us today in the presence of Yahweh our God, and also with those who
are not here with us today.
16 "You know how we lived in the land of Egypt and how we passed
through the midst of the nations you passed through. 17 You saw
their abominations and their idols of wood and stone, silver and gold,
which were among them. 18 Beware, lest there be among you a man or
woman, family or tribe, whose heart turns away today from Yahweh
our God to go and serve the gods of those nations; lest there be among
you a root that produces gall and bitterness, 19 someone who, on
hearing the words of this oath, blesses himself in his heart, thinking, 'I
will be safe, though I walk in the stubbornness of my heart,' bringing
ruin on watered and dry land alike.[b] 20 Yahweh will not be willing to
forgive him. Instead the anger and jealousy of Yahweh will smoke

against that man, and every curse written in this book will settle on him, and Yahweh will blot out his name from under heaven. 21 Yahweh will single him out from all the tribes of Israel for disaster, according to all the curses of the covenant written in this book of the law. 22 And the generation to come, your children who rise up after you, and the foreigner who comes from a distant land, will see the plagues of that land and the sicknesses with which Yahweh has afflicted it— 23 the whole land burned out with sulfur and salt, nothing sown, nothing sprouting, no plant growing in it, an overthrow like that of Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, which Yahweh overthrew in his anger and wrath— 24 and all the nations will say, 'Why has Yahweh done this to this land? What was the reason for this great burning anger?' 25 Then people will say, 'It is because they abandoned the covenant of Yahweh, the God of their forefathers, which he made with them when he brought them out of the land of Egypt. 26 They went and served other gods and worshiped them, gods they had not known and that he had not allotted to them. 27 That is why Yahweh's anger blazed against this land, so that he brought upon it all the curses recorded in this book. 28 And Yahweh uprooted them from their land in anger and fury and great indignation, and flung them into another land, as it is this day.'

29 "The hidden things belong to Yahweh our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our children forever,[c] so that we may do all the words of this law.

Notes

- a (29:1) Verse 1 is 28:69 in the Hebrew text, and verses 2–29 are numbered 1–28.
- b (29:19) Hebrew "to sweep away the watered with the dry," probably a proverb meaning total destruction.
- c (29:29) In the Hebrew text the words "to us and to our children" are marked with extraordinary dots (puncta extraordinaria), whose meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 30

1 "When all these things have come upon you, the blessing and the curse I have set before you, and you call them to mind among all the nations where Yahweh your God has driven you, 2 and you return to Yahweh your God and listen to his voice in everything I command

you today, you and your children, with all your heart and with all your soul, 3 then Yahweh your God will bring back your captives[a] and have mercy on you; he will gather you again from all the peoples where Yahweh your God has dispersed you. 4 Even if your exiles are at the far edge of the sky, from there Yahweh your God will gather you, and from there he will fetch you. 5 Yahweh your God will bring you into the land your forefathers possessed, and you will possess it. He will do you good and make you more numerous than your forefathers. 6 And Yahweh your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your descendants, so that you will love Yahweh your God with your whole heart and your whole soul, in order that you may live. 7 And Yahweh your God will lay all these curses on your enemies and on those who hate and persecute you. 8 You will again obey the voice of Yahweh and keep all his commands that I give you today. 9 Yahweh your God will make you overflow with good things in all the work of your hands, in the children you bear, in the young of your animals, and in the crops of your ground. For Yahweh will again take delight in your welfare, as he delighted in your forefathers, 10 when you listen to the voice of Yahweh your God by keeping his commands and his statutes written in this book of the law, and when you turn to Yahweh your God with all your heart and with all your soul.
11 "This command I give you today is not too hard for you, nor is it out of your reach. 12 It is not up in the heavens, so that you should say, 'Who will climb up to heaven for us and bring it down to us, and tell it to us so that we may do it?' 13 Nor is it beyond the sea, so that you need ask, 'Who will go across the sea on our behalf, bring it to us, and have us hear it, so that we may do it?' 14 No, the word is very close to you, in your mouth and in your heart, so that you can do it.
15 "See, today I have laid before you life and good, death and evil. 16 For I command you today to love Yahweh your God, to walk in his ways, and to keep his commands, his statutes, and his rulings, so that you may live and multiply, and Yahweh your God will bless you in the land you are entering to possess.[b] 17 But if your heart turns away and you refuse to listen, and you are drawn off to bow to other gods and serve them, 18 I declare to you today that you shall surely perish;

you will not prolong your days on the soil that you cross the Jordan to enter and possess. 19 I call heaven and earth to witness against you today: I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. So choose life, that you and your descendants may live, 20 loving Yahweh your God, listening to his voice, and holding fast to him. For he is your life and the length of your days, so that you may dwell in the land Yahweh swore to give to your forefathers, to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob."

Notes

- a (30:3) Or "bring you back from captivity."
- b (30:16) The Septuagint begins this verse, "If you hearken to the commandments of the Lord your God, which I command you this day" (Brenton, modernized), a clause missing from the traditional Hebrew text.

Chapter 31

1 Then Moses went and spoke[a] these words to all Israel. 2 And he said to them, "Today I am one hundred twenty years old; I can no longer go out and come in, and Yahweh has said to me, 'You shall not cross this Jordan.' 3 Yahweh your God is the one who will go across in front of you. It is he who will wipe out these nations before you so that you take their place. And Joshua will lead you across, just as Yahweh has said. 4 And Yahweh will deal with them as he dealt with Sihon and Og, the kings of the Amorites, and with their land, which he destroyed. 5 Yahweh will hand them over to you, and you must treat them exactly as the command I have given you requires. 6 Be strong and brave. Do not fear them or tremble before them, for it is Yahweh your God who goes with you. He will not let you go or abandon you."

7 Then Moses called Joshua and said to him in the sight of all Israel, "Be strong and brave, for you will go with this people into the land Yahweh swore to their forefathers to give them, and you will divide it among them as their inheritance. 8 Yahweh himself goes before you; he will be with you. He will not let you go or abandon you. Do not be afraid or dismayed."

9 Moses wrote down this law and gave it to the priests, the sons of Levi, who carried the ark of Yahweh's covenant, and to all the elders of Israel. 10 Then Moses gave them this command: "Every seventh

year, at the set time of the year when debts are released, during the Feast of Booths,[b] 11 when all Israel comes to appear in the presence of Yahweh your God at the place he will choose, you shall read this law before all Israel, in their hearing. 12 Assemble the people, men, women, and children, and the sojourner in your gates, so that they may listen and learn to revere Yahweh your God and be careful to observe every word of this law, 13 and that their children, who have not known it, may listen and learn to revere Yahweh your God as long as you live in the land that you are crossing the Jordan to possess."
14 Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Your time to die is drawing near. Summon Joshua, and both of you take your stand in the tent of meeting, and I will give him his charge." So Moses and Joshua went and stood in the tent of meeting. 15 And Yahweh appeared at the tent in a pillar of cloud, and the pillar of cloud stood over the entrance of the tent. 16 Yahweh said to Moses, "Soon you will lie down to rest with your forefathers, and this people will rise up and go whoring after the alien gods of the land into which they are going. They will abandon me and break the covenant I made with them. 17 My anger will be kindled against them on that day, and I will forsake them and conceal my face from them; they will be consumed, and many disasters and distresses will befall them. And they will say on that day, 'Have not these disasters come upon us because our God is not in our midst?' 18 On that day I will indeed turn my face away from them, on account of all the wickedness they have committed by turning to other gods.
19 "Now therefore write this song for yourselves, and teach it to the Israelites; put it in their mouths, that this song may be a witness for me against the Israelites. 20 For I will bring them into the land flowing with milk and honey that I promised on oath to their forefathers, and when they have eaten until they are full and have become fat, they will go after other gods and serve them, scorning me and breaking my covenant. 21 And when many evils and troubles have found them, this song will testify against them as a witness, for it will not be forgotten from the mouths of their offspring. For I know the plans they are forming even today, before I have brought them into the land I swore

to give." 22 So Moses wrote this song down on that day and taught it to the Israelites.
23 And Yahweh[c] commissioned Joshua the son of Nun and said, "Be strong and courageous, for you shall bring the Israelites into the land that I swore to them, and I will be with you."
24 When Moses had finished writing the words of this law in a book, to the very end, 25 he gave this command to the Levites, the bearers of the ark of Yahweh's covenant: 26 "Take this book of the law and put it beside the ark of the covenant of Yahweh your God, so that it may stay there as a witness against you. 27 For I know how rebellious and stiff-necked you are. If even today, while I am still alive among you, you have been rebels against Yahweh, how much more after my death! 28 Gather to me all the elders of your tribes and your officials, that I may speak these words in their ears and call heaven and earth to witness against them. 29 For I know that after my death you will act very corruptly and turn aside from the way I have commanded you. Disaster will meet you in later days, because you will do what Yahweh regards as evil, and anger him through what your hands have made."
30 Then, while the whole assembly of Israel listened, Moses spoke the words of this song from beginning to end:

Notes

- a (31:1) The Septuagint reads "Moses finished speaking" (Brenton), and a Qumran manuscript is reported to agree; the difference involves two similar Hebrew words.
- b (31:10) Held in the seventh month, Tishri (September–October).
- c (31:23) Hebrew "he"; the context shows that Yahweh is meant. The Septuagint makes Moses the subject.

Chapter 32

1 "Give ear, you heavens, and I will speak; let the earth hear the words of my mouth. 2 Let my teaching fall like rain, my speech settle like the dew, like fine showers on new grass, like heavy rains on the green plants. 3 For I will proclaim the name of Yahweh; give greatness to our God!
4 "The Rock—his work is perfect; all his ways are justice. A God of faithfulness and without wrong, righteous and upright is he. 5 Acting corruptly toward him, they are no longer his children, because of

their blemish;[a] a perverse and crooked generation. 6 Is this how you
repay Yahweh, you foolish and unwise people? Is he not your father,
who acquired you,[b] who made you and established you?
7 "Remember the days of long ago; consider the years of generations
past. Ask your father, and he will inform you, your elders, and
they will tell you. 8 When the Most High[c] gave the nations their
inheritance, when he divided the descendants of Adam,[d] he fixed the
borders of the peoples according to the number of the sons of Israel.[e]
9 For Yahweh's portion is his people, Jacob his allotted inheritance.
10 "He found him in a desert land, in an empty, howling waste. He
encircled him and watched over him; he guarded him like the pupil[f]
of his eye. 11 Like an eagle that rouses its nest and hovers over its
young, he spread out his wings and took him up, bearing him on his
pinions. 12 Yahweh by himself was his guide; there was no alien god
beside him. 13 He made him ride on the heights of the land, and he
ate the produce of the field. He fed him honey from the rock and oil
from the flinty crag, 14 curds from the herd and milk from the flock,
with the fat of lambs, rams of Bashan's breed and he-goats, with the
choicest kernels of wheat; and you drank wine, the foaming blood of
the grape.
15 "But Jeshurun[g] grew fat and kicked— you grew fat, you grew bloated
and gorged— he abandoned the God who made him and scorned the
Rock of his salvation. 16 They made him jealous with strange gods;
they angered him with detestable things. 17 They sacrificed to demons
that were no god, to gods they had never known, to new gods lately
arrived, whom your forefathers never dreaded. 18 You neglected the
Rock that begot you, and forgot the God who gave you birth.
19 "Yahweh saw it and spurned them, provoked by his sons and his
daughters. 20 He said, 'I will hide my face from them; I will see what
their end will be, for they are a perverse generation, children with
no faithfulness in them. 21 They roused my jealousy with a no-god;
they angered me with their empty idols.[h] So I will rouse their jealousy
with a no-people; I will anger them with a nation that lacks sense. 22
For fire has flared up in my anger, and it burns down to the depths of

Sheol;[i] it consumes the earth and its harvest and sets the roots of the mountains ablaze.
23 " 'I will pile up evils on them; I will spend every arrow I have against
them. 24 They will be wasted by hunger, devoured by plague and bitter
pestilence. I will send the fangs of wild beasts against them, with
the venom of things that glide in the dust. 25 Outside, the sword will
bereave, and in the inner rooms, terror, for young man and virgin
alike, for the nursing infant and the gray-haired man. 26 I said, "I will
scatter them,[j] I will erase their memory from among mankind," 27 but I
feared the taunting of the enemy, that their foes might misjudge and
say, "Our hand has prevailed; Yahweh did not do any of this." '
28 "For they are a nation void of counsel, and there is no understanding
in them. 29 If they were wise, they would grasp this; they would see
what their end will be. 30 How could a single man pursue a thousand,
and two drive ten thousand into flight, unless their Rock had sold
them, unless Yahweh had given them up? 31 For their rock is not like
our Rock— even our enemies are judges of that. 32 For their vine comes
from the vine of Sodom and from the terraces of Gomorrah; their
grapes are full of poison; their clusters taste of bitterness. 33 Their wine
is the venom of serpents, the cruel poison of vipers.
34 " 'Is this not stored away with me, sealed up in my treasuries? 35
Vengeance and recompense are mine,[k] for the time when their foot
shall slip; for their day of calamity is at hand, and their doom comes
swiftly.' 36 For Yahweh will judge his people and relent concerning
his servants, when he sees that their power has vanished and none
remain, whether bound or free. 37 Then he will say, 'Where are their
gods, the rock in which they sought refuge, 38 who ate the fat of their
sacrifices and drank the wine of their drink offerings? Let them get
up and help you; let them be a shelter over you!
39 "'See now that I, even I, am he, and there is no god beside me; I
am the one who puts to death and gives life; I have wounded, and
I myself heal, and none can deliver from my hand. 40 For I raise my
hand to heaven and say, As I live forever, 41 once I whet my lightning
sword and my hand grasps judgment, I will pay back vengeance to
my foes and repay those who hate me. 42 I will make my arrows drunk

with blood, and my sword will feed on flesh, with the blood of the slain and the captives, from the heads of the long-haired leaders of the enemy.'[l]

43 "Shout for joy, you nations, over his people,[m] for he will avenge
the blood of his servants. He will pay back vengeance to his foes and
make atonement for his land and his people."[n]

44 Moses came and recited all the words of this song in the ears of
the people, he and Hoshea[o] son of Nun. 45 When Moses had finished
speaking all these words to all Israel, 46 he said to them, "Set your
hearts on all the words I testify to you today, so that you may
command your children to take care to do every word of this law. 47
For this is no empty word for you; it is your very life. Through this
word your days will be long on the soil you are going over the Jordan
to possess."

48 That same day Yahweh spoke to Moses: 49 "Go up this Abarim
mountain range,[p] to Mount Nebo, in the land of Moab across from
Jericho, and look at the land of Canaan, which I am giving to the
Israelites for a possession; 50 and die on the mountain you are about to
ascend, and be gathered to your people, as your brother Aaron died
on Mount Hor and was gathered to his people, 51 because you both
broke faith with me among the Israelites at the waters of Meribah-
kadesh[q] in the Wilderness of Zin, by failing to uphold my holiness
among the Israelites. 52 You will see the land from a distance, but you
will not go into the land I am giving to the Israelites."

Notes

- a (32:5) The Hebrew of this line is obscure. The Septuagint reads "spotted children" (Brenton).
- b (32:6) Or "created you."
- c (32:8) Hebrew 'Elyon, a title of God meaning "highest."
- d (32:8) Or "humankind"; Hebrew "the sons of Adam."
- e (32:8) So the traditional Hebrew text (MT). A Hebrew manuscript from Qumran (4QDeut-j) reads "the sons of God," and many scholars regard that as the earlier reading. The Septuagint reads "the angels of God" (Brenton), and some Greek manuscripts are reported to read "the sons of God." The difference bears on whether the nations are allotted to heavenly beings under the Most High (compare 4:19; 29:26). This needs scholarly review.
- f (32:10) Hebrew "the little man of his eye."

- g (32:15) Jeshurun means "upright one," a poetic name for Israel. The Septuagint reads "So Jacob ate and was filled, and the beloved one kicked" (Brenton).
- h (32:21) Hebrew hebel, "vapor" or "breath."
- i (32:22) Sheol is the realm of the dead.
- j (32:26) Hebrew uncertain; perhaps "cut them in pieces" or "blow them away."
- k (32:35) The Septuagint reads "In the day of vengeance I will recompense" (Brenton). Romans 12:19 and Hebrews 10:30 quote this line as "Vengeance is mine; I will repay."
- l (32:42) Or "from the heads of the enemy's leaders."
- m (32:43) Or "Praise his people, you nations." The traditional Hebrew wording is brief and can be read several ways.
- n (32:43) This verse is much longer in other ancient witnesses. The Septuagint reads (Brenton, modernized): "Rejoice, you heavens, with him, and let all the angels of God worship him; rejoice, you Gentiles, with his people, and let all the sons of God strengthen themselves in him; for he will avenge the blood of his sons, and he will render vengeance, and recompense justice to his enemies, and will reward those who hate him; and the Lord shall purge the land of his people." A Hebrew manuscript from Qumran (4QDeut-q) is reported to have a longer text than the traditional Hebrew as well, including a call to the heavens to rejoice and to the gods (or heavenly beings) to bow down to him. Hebrews 1:6 and Romans 15:10 appear to draw on the longer form. This needs scholarly review.
- o (32:44) Hoshea means "salvation," the earlier name of Joshua (Numbers 13:16). The Septuagint reads "Joshua" (Brenton, "Joshua the son of Naue"), and it also begins the verse, "And Moses wrote this song in that day, and taught it to the children of Israel."
- p (32:49) Abarim means "regions beyond," the range east of the Jordan facing Jericho.
- q (32:51) Meribah means "quarreling"; see Numbers 20:1–13.

Chapter 33

1 Here is the blessing which Moses, the man of God, spoke over the
Israelites before he died. 2 He said: "Yahweh came from Sinai, and rose
from Seir upon them; he shone forth from Mount Paran, and came
with ten thousands of holy ones;[a] at his right hand was a flaming fire[b]
for them. 3 Truly he loves the peoples;[c] all his holy ones are in your
hand. They sit at your feet, each receiving your words. 4 Moses gave
us a law, a possession for the assembly of Jacob. 5 And there was a
king in Jeshurun, when the heads of the people gathered, the tribes
of Israel together.
6 "Let Reuben live and not die, though his men be few."

7 And this he said for Judah: “Hear, Yahweh, the voice of Judah, and
bring him in to his people. With his own hands he fights for his
cause;[d] be his help against his foes.”
8 For Levi he said: “Your Thummim and your Urim[e] belong to your
faithful man, whom you tested at Massah, with whom you strove at
the waters of Meribah; 9 who said of his father and of his mother,
‘I regard them not’; he did not acknowledge his brothers, nor know
his own children. For they have observed your word and kept your
covenant. 10 They teach your rulings to Jacob and your law to Israel;
they set incense before you[f] and whole burnt offerings on your altar.
11 Bless, Yahweh, his strength, and take pleasure in the work of his
hands. Smash the loins of his attackers, of those who hate him, so
that they rise no more.”
12 For Benjamin he said: “The one Yahweh loves dwells in safety
beside him. He shelters him all day long, and he rests between his
shoulders.”[g]
13 For Joseph he said: “May his land be blessed by Yahweh with the
choicest gifts of heaven, the dew, and of the deep that crouches below,
14 with the choicest yield of the sun and the rich produce of the
months,[h] 15 with the finest things of the ancient mountains and the
wealth of the hills that last forever, 16 and with the choicest gifts of
the earth and its fullness, and the good will of him who lived in the
bush. May they come on the head of Joseph, on the brow of the prince
among his brothers. 17 His firstborn bull has majesty, and his horns
are the horns of the wild ox; with them he shall gore peoples, every
one, to earth’s farthest limits; they are the ten thousands of Ephraim,
and they are the thousands of Manasseh.”
18 For Zebulun he said: “Rejoice, Zebulun, as you go out, and you,
Issachar, in your tents. 19 They will summon peoples to the mountain;
there they will offer right sacrifices, for they will draw on the wealth
of the seas and the treasures hidden in the sand.”
20 For Gad he said: “Blessed be the one who makes Gad’s land wide!
Gad lies in wait like a lioness and tears off arm and scalp alike. 21 He
chose the first part for himself, for a ruler’s portion was kept for him

there. He came with the heads of the people; he carried out the justice of Yahweh and his rulings for Israel."

22 For Dan he said: "Dan is a lion's whelp that springs out from Bashan."

23 For Naphtali he said: "Naphtali, filled with favor and full of Yahweh's blessing, take possession of the sea[i] and the south."

24 For Asher he said: "Asher is blessed above the other sons; let his brothers look on him with favor, and may he bathe his feet in oil. 25 Your bolts will be of iron and bronze, and your strength[j] will last as long as your days.

26 "There is none like God, Jeshurun, who rides the heavens to your aid, and the clouds in his majesty. 27 The God of old is your dwelling place,[k] and underneath are the arms that last forever. He drove out the enemy before you and said, 'Destroy!' 28 So Israel dwells in safety, the spring of Jacob undisturbed,[l] in a land of grain and new wine, where the heavens drip with dew. 29 How happy you are, Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by Yahweh, the shield that helps you and the sword of your triumph? Your enemies will come cringing to you, and you will tread upon their high places."[m]

Notes

- a (33:2) Or "from Ribeboth-kodesh," perhaps a place name. The Septuagint reads "with the ten thousands of Kadesh" (Brenton, "Cades").
- b (33:2) Hebrew uncertain. The written Hebrew has a single obscure word; it is traditionally read as two words, "fire of law." The Septuagint reads "on his right hand were his angels with him" (Brenton).
- c (33:3) Or "his people." The Septuagint reads "he spared his people" (Brenton).
- d (33:7) Or "his hands are enough for him."
- e (33:8) The Urim and Thummim were the priestly lots used to seek God's will; the names may mean "lights" and "perfections." The Septuagint begins, "Give to Levi" (Brenton), and a Qumran manuscript is reported to read similarly.
- f (33:10) Hebrew "in your nostrils."
- g (33:12) Or "and he dwells among his slopes," perhaps a reference to the temple hill in Benjamin's territory.
- h (33:14) Or "moons."
- i (33:23) Or "the west." Hebrew yam can mean "sea" or "west"; here perhaps the Sea of Galilee.
- j (33:25) Hebrew uncertain; the word may mean "strength" or "rest."
- k (33:27) Or "refuge."

- l (33:28) Or “alone.”
- m (33:29) Or “trample on their backs.”

Chapter 34

1 Then Moses went up from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo, to the
summit of Pisgah, which faces Jericho, and Yahweh showed him the
whole land: Gilead as far as Dan, 2 all of Naphtali, the land of Ephraim
and Manasseh, all the land of Judah up to the sea in the west,[a] 3 the
Negev,[b] and the plain of the valley of Jericho, the city of palm trees,
as far as Zoar. 4 Then Yahweh said to him, “This is the land I swore to
Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob when I said, ‘To your offspring I will
give it.’ I have shown it to you, and you have seen it, but you yourself
will not go over there.”
5 So Moses, the servant of Yahweh, died there in the land of Moab, as
Yahweh had said.[c] 6 And he buried him[d] in the valley in the land of
Moab opposite Beth Peor; but his burial place is unknown to this day.
7 Moses was 120 years old when he died. His sight had not grown dim,
and his vigor had not left him. 8 The Israelites mourned for Moses in
the plains of Moab thirty days, until the days of weeping in mourning
for Moses were complete.
9 Now Joshua son of Nun was full of the spirit of wisdom, since Moses
had placed his hands upon him, and the Israelites obeyed him and did
what Yahweh had commanded Moses.
10 Never since has a prophet arisen in Israel like Moses, whom Yahweh
knew face to face, 11 none like him for all the signs and wonders
Yahweh sent him to perform in Egypt against Pharaoh and against all
his officials and his whole land, 12 and for all the mighty deeds and all
the great and awesome acts that Moses did in the sight of all Israel.

Notes

- a (34:2) That is, the Mediterranean.
- b (34:3) Negev means “dry land,” the arid south of Judah.
- c (34:5) Hebrew “at the mouth of Yahweh.” Later Jewish tradition read this as “by the kiss of Yahweh.”
- d (34:6) That is, Yahweh buried him. Or “he was buried.” The Septuagint reads “they buried him” (Brenton).

Joshua

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 After the death of Moses the servant of Yahweh, Yahweh said to
Joshua[a] the son of Nun,[b] Moses' assistant, 2 "My servant Moses has
died. So now get up and go across this Jordan,[c] you and all these
people, to the land I am about to give them—to the Israelites. 3 Every
place on which the sole of your foot treads I have given to you, as I
promised Moses. 4 Your territory will stretch from the wilderness and
this Lebanon[d] to the great river, the Euphrates—the whole land of the
Hittites—and west to the Great Sea[e] where the sun goes down. 5 No
one will be able to stand before you all the days of your life. As I was
with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not fail you or forsake you.
6 Be strong and courageous, for you will cause this people to inherit
the land that I swore to their fathers to give them. 7 Just be strong and
very bold, and take care to carry out the whole law that my servant
Moses commanded you. Do not stray from it to the right or the left,
so that you will prosper[f] wherever you go. 8 This book of the law must
not depart from your mouth, but you are to meditate[g] on it day and
night, so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written
in it. For then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will
succeed. 9 Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous.
Do not be terrified or dismayed, for Yahweh your God is with you
wherever you go."
10 Then Joshua commanded the officers of the people, saying, 11 "Go
through the camp and give the people this order: 'Get your provisions
ready, because in three days you will cross this Jordan to enter and
take the land Yahweh your God is giving you as your possession.'"
12 To the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh
Joshua said, 13 "Remember the word that Moses the servant of Yahweh
commanded you, saying, 'Yahweh your God is giving you rest and

will give you this land.' 14 Your wives, children, and livestock may stay
in the land Moses gave you east of the Jordan,[h] but all of you who are
mighty warriors must cross over armed[i] ahead of your brothers and
help them, 15 until Yahweh gives your brothers rest as he has given
you, and they also take possession of the land that Yahweh your God
is giving them. Then you may return to the land of your possession
and possess it, the land that Moses the servant of Yahweh gave you
beyond the Jordan toward the sunrise."
16 They answered Joshua, saying, "All that you have commanded us
we will do, and wherever you send us we will go. 17 Just as we obeyed
Moses in all things, so we will obey you. Only may Yahweh your God
be with you as he was with Moses. 18 "Anyone who rebels against your
order and will not obey your words, whatever you command him,
shall be put to death. Just be strong and courageous."

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew Yehoshua', "Yahweh is salvation" (or "Yahweh saves"). His earlier name was Hoshea, "salvation" (Numbers 13:16). The Greek form of the name is Iesous, "Jesus."
- b (1:1) Nun may mean "fish." The Septuagint spells it Naue.
- c (1:2) Hebrew Yarden, probably "the one that goes down," fitting the river's steep descent to the Dead Sea.
- d (1:4) Lebanon means "white," perhaps from its snowy peaks or limestone cliffs. The Septuagint reads "Antilibanus."
- e (1:4) That is, the Mediterranean Sea.
- f (1:7) Or "act wisely"; so in verse 8.
- g (1:8) Hebrew hagah, to murmur or read in an undertone (compare Psalm 1:2).
- h (1:14) That is, east of the Jordan.
- i (1:14) Or "in battle formation"; the Hebrew ḥamushim is related to the word for "five," perhaps describing an army in five divisions.

Chapter 2

1 Joshua the son of Nun secretly sent two men as spies from Shittim,[a]
saying, "Go, look over the land, especially Jericho."[b] So they went and
came into the house of a prostitute[c] whose name was Rahab,[d] and
lodged there. 2 It was told the king of Jericho, "Look, men from the
Israelites have come here tonight to search out the land." 3 Then the
king of Jericho sent this message to Rahab: "Bring forth the men who

came to you, the ones now in your house, for they came to scout out all the land." 4 The woman, however, had taken the two men and hidden them. She replied, "True, men did come to me, though I had no idea where they were from. 5 At dark, when the gate was about to close, the men left. Where they went I do not know. Chase after them quickly, and you will catch them." 6 But she had brought them up to the roof and hidden them under the stalks of flax that she had laid out on the roof. 7 The men chased after them along the road to the Jordan, toward the fords, and as soon as the pursuers had gone out, the gate was shut behind them.

8 Before the men lay down, she came up to them on the roof 9 and said to the men, "I know that Yahweh has given the land to you, that dread of you has fallen on us, and that everyone living in the land is melting away because of you. 10 For we have heard how Yahweh dried up the water of the Red Sea[e] before you when you came out of Egypt, and what you did to the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan, to Sihon and Og, whom you devoted to destruction.[f] 11 When we heard it, our hearts melted, and no courage remained in anyone because of you, for Yahweh your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath. 12 Now then, please swear to me by Yahweh, since I have dealt kindly with you, that you also will deal kindly with my father's house, and give me a sure sign, 13 and that you will let my father, my mother, my brothers, my sisters, and everyone belonging to them live, and rescue our lives from death." 14 The men said to her, "We pledge our own lives for yours, even to the death![g] If you do not reveal this business of ours, then when Yahweh gives us the land we will treat you with kindness and loyalty."

15 Then she let them down by a rope through the window, for her house was in the town wall, and she lived in the wall. 16 She said to them, "Go into the hill country, so that the pursuers do not meet you. Hide there three days until the pursuers have returned, and afterward you may go on your way." 17 The men said to her, "We will be free from this oath of yours that you have made us swear, 18 unless, as we enter the land, you fasten this cord of scarlet thread to the window by which you lowered us, and bring your father, mother, brothers, and

all your father's household together into your house. [19] Anyone who goes out from the doors of your house into the street will have his blood on his own head, and we will be free of blame. But for anyone with you in the house, his blood will be on our heads if any hand is laid on him. [20] But if you tell this business of ours, then we will be free from your oath that you have made us swear." [21] She said, "According to your words, so be it." Then she sent them away, and they departed. And she tied the scarlet cord in the window.

[22] They went and came into the hill country and stayed there three days, until the pursuers returned. The pursuers searched all along the way but did not find them. [23] The two men then came back down from the hill country, crossed the river, and came to Joshua son of Nun, and reported to him everything that had happened to them. [24] They said to Joshua, "Truly Yahweh has given all the land into our hands, and all the inhabitants of the land melt away before us."

Notes

- a (2:1) Shittim means "acacia trees" (Numbers 25:1).
- b (2:1) Jericho may mean "moon city," from yareaḥ, "moon," or "fragrant place," from reaḥ, "scent." The meaning is uncertain.
- c (2:1) Hebrew zonah. Josephus and the Aramaic Targum understood her as an innkeeper, but the Hebrew word means "prostitute," as the Septuagint (pornē) and the New Testament (Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25) take it.
- d (2:1) Rahab means "broad" or "wide." She appears in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:5).
- e (2:10) Hebrew Yam Suph, "Sea of Reeds."
- f (2:10) Hebrew ḥaram, to give something over completely to Yahweh, usually by destroying it. See the note at 6:17.
- g (2:14) Literally "Our life in place of yours, to die."

Chapter 3

[1] Early in the morning Joshua got up, and he and all the Israelites set out from Shittim and came to the Jordan; there they stayed before crossing over. [2] At the end of three days the officers went through the middle of the camp [3] and commanded the people, saying, "When you see the ark of the covenant of Yahweh your God being carried by the Levitical priests, then you are to set out from your place and follow it. [4] There must be a space between you and it of about 3,000

feet,[a] measured out. Stay back from it, so that you will know which way to go, since you have not traveled this way before." 5 Joshua said to the people, "Consecrate yourselves, for tomorrow Yahweh will do wonders among you." 6 To the priests Joshua said, "Lift up the ark of the covenant and cross over ahead of the people." They lifted it and walked ahead of the people.

7 Yahweh said to Joshua, "Today I will begin to exalt you in the sight of all Israel, so that they may know that as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. 8 You yourself are to command the priests carrying the ark of the covenant: 'When you reach the edge of the Jordan's waters, stand still in the Jordan.'"

9 Joshua said to the Israelites, "Come here and listen to the words of Yahweh your God." 10 Joshua said, "By this you will know that the living God is among you, and that he will surely drive out before you the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Hivites, the Perizzites, the Girgashites, the Amorites, and the Jebusites. 11 Look, the ark of the covenant of the Lord of all the earth goes ahead of you into the Jordan. 12 Now therefore take twelve men from the tribes of Israel, one man from each tribe. 13 When the soles of the feet of the priests who carry the ark of Yahweh, the Lord of all the earth, rest in the waters of the Jordan, the waters of the Jordan will be cut off, the waters coming down from above, and they will stand in one heap."

14 So when the people set out from their tents to cross over the Jordan, with the priests carrying the ark of the covenant before the people, 15 and when those carrying the ark reached the Jordan and the priests' feet touched the water's edge (the Jordan overflows all its banks throughout the harvest season),[b] 16 the waters flowing down from upstream stopped and stood up in a single heap, a great distance away at Adam,[c] the city next to Zarethan,[d] while the waters running down to the Sea of the Arabah, the Salt Sea,[e] were entirely cut off, and the people crossed over facing Jericho. 17 The priests who carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh stood firmly on dry ground in the Jordan's middle while all Israel crossed over on dry ground, until the entire nation had finished crossing the Jordan.

Notes

- a (3:4) Hebrew “two thousand cubits,” about 900 meters.
- b (3:15) That is, the barley and wheat harvest in spring (April–May), when the Jordan was swollen with rain and melting snow from Mount Hermon. Compare 4:19.
- c (3:16) Adam means “red” or “earth,” perhaps from the color of its soil. It is probably Tell ed-Damiyeh, about 18 miles (30 kilometers) north of Jericho. Medieval Arabic sources report that landslides there blocked the Jordan in A.D. 1267, and an earthquake did so again in 1927. The Hebrew reads “at Adam,” following the qere (the reading tradition); the written text has “in Adam.”
- d (3:16) The location of Zarethan is uncertain.
- e (3:16) That is, the Dead Sea.

Chapter 4

1 When all the nation had finished crossing over the Jordan, Yahweh
said to Joshua, 2 “Take for yourselves twelve men from the people, one
man from each tribe, 3 and tell them: ‘From this spot in the middle of
the Jordan, where the priests’ feet stood firm, pick up twelve stones
for yourselves, carry them across with you, and set them down in the
place where you will stay tonight.’” 4 Then Joshua called the twelve
men whom he had appointed from the Israelites, one man from each
tribe. 5 Joshua said to them, “Cross over before the ark of Yahweh
your God into the middle of the Jordan, and each of you lift a stone on
his shoulder, according to the number of the tribes of the Israelites,
6 so that this may be a sign among you. When your children ask in
time to come, ‘What do these stones mean to you?’ 7 you are to tell
them that the waters of the Jordan were cut off before the ark of the
covenant of Yahweh. When it crossed over the Jordan, the waters of
the Jordan were cut off. So these stones are to be a memorial to the
Israelites forever.”
8 The Israelites did exactly as Joshua had ordered: they picked up
twelve stones from the Jordan’s middle, matching the number of the
tribes of Israel, as Yahweh had told Joshua, carried them to their
campsite, and set them down there. 9 Joshua also set up twelve stones
in the middle of the Jordan,[a] in the place where the feet of the priests
carrying the ark of the covenant had stood, and they are there to
this day.

10 The priests who carried the ark stayed standing in the Jordan's
middle until everything Yahweh had commanded Joshua to tell the
people was done, in keeping with all that Moses had ordered Joshua.
And the people hurried across. 11 When all the people had finished
crossing over, the ark of Yahweh and the priests crossed over before
the people. 12 The Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of
Manasseh crossed over armed before the Israelites, as Moses had told
them. 13 About forty thousand armed for war crossed over before
Yahweh for battle, to the plains of Jericho. 14 That day Yahweh made
Joshua great in the eyes of all Israel, and they stood in awe of him all
his life, as they had of Moses.
15 Yahweh said to Joshua, 16 "Command the priests carrying the ark of
the testimony to come up out of the Jordan." 17 So Joshua commanded
the priests, saying, "Come up out of the Jordan." 18 When the priests
carrying the ark of the covenant of Yahweh came up from the middle
of the Jordan, and the soles of the priests' feet were lifted up onto dry
ground, the waters of the Jordan returned to their place and ran over
all its banks as before.
19 The people came up out of the Jordan on the tenth day of the first
month (in March–April),[b] and they camped at Gilgal[c] on the east
border of Jericho. 20 As for the twelve stones taken from the Jordan,
Joshua set them up at Gilgal. 21 He said to the Israelites, "When your
children ask their fathers in time to come, 'What are these stones?'
22 then you are to let your children know, 'Israel crossed over this
Jordan on dry ground.' 23 For Yahweh your God dried up the waters
of the Jordan before you until you had crossed over, as Yahweh your
God did to the Red Sea, which he dried up before us until we had
crossed over, 24 so that all the peoples of the earth may know that the
hand of Yahweh is mighty, and that you may fear Yahweh your God
forever."

Notes

- a (4:9) Or "Joshua set up the twelve stones that had been in the middle of the Jordan." The Septuagint reads "other twelve stones," and the Latin Vulgate also speaks of a second set in the riverbed.

- b (4:19) Hebrew “in the first month,” counted from the spring new year of Israel’s religious calendar (Exodus 12:2). It was called Abib and later Nisan. Because the Hebrew months were lunar, it fell in March–April. The tenth day was the day the Passover lamb was chosen (Exodus 12:3).
- c (4:19) Gilgal means “circle,” probably a circle of stones. Joshua 5:9 links the name with galal, “to roll away.”

Chapter 5

1 When the kings of the Amorites on the Jordan’s west side, together
with all the kings of the Canaanites by the sea, heard how Yahweh
had dried up the Jordan’s waters in front of the Israelites until we[a]
crossed over, their hearts melted, and they had no spirit left to face
the Israelites.
2 Yahweh said to Joshua at that time,[b] “Make yourself flint knives and
circumcise the Israelites a second time.” 3 So Joshua made flint knives
for himself and circumcised the Israelites at Gibeath-haaraloth.[c] 4 This
is the reason Joshua circumcised them: all the people who came out
of Egypt, the males, all the men of war, had died in the wilderness
on the way after they came out of Egypt. 5 All the people who came
out of Egypt had been circumcised, but none of those born in the
wilderness on the journey out of Egypt had been. 6 The Israelites
had walked in the wilderness forty years, until the whole nation—the
men of war who left Egypt—died out, because they had not obeyed
Yahweh’s voice. Yahweh had sworn to them that he would not let
them see the land he swore to their fathers to give us, a land flowing
with milk and honey.[d] 7 Their sons, whom he raised up in their place,
were the ones Joshua circumcised, since they were uncircumcised,
not having been circumcised during the journey. 8 When they had
finished circumcising all the nation, they stayed in their places in the
camp until they were healed. 9 Yahweh said to Joshua, “This day I
have rolled off[e] you the disgrace of Egypt.” That is why the place is
named Gilgal to this day.
10 While the Israelites were camped at Gilgal, they kept the Passover
on the fourteenth day of the month (in March–April),[f] at evening, in
the plains of Jericho. 11 The day after the Passover, on that very day,
they ate unleavened bread and roasted grain[g] from the produce of the

land. 12 The manna stopped the next day, when they ate the land's
produce; the Israelites had no more manna, and that year they ate
from the crops of Canaan.
13 When Joshua was by Jericho, he lifted up his eyes and looked, and
there was a man standing before him with his drawn sword in his
hand. Joshua went to him and said to him, "Are you for us or for our
adversaries?" 14 "No," he said, "but I have just now come as commander
of Yahweh's army." Joshua fell with his face to the ground, worshiped,
and asked him, "What does my lord have to say to his servant?" 15 The
commander of Yahweh's army said to Joshua, "Take off your sandal
from your foot, for the place where you are standing is holy." And
Joshua did so.

Notes

- a (5:1) So the Hebrew written text (ketiv). The qere (the reading tradition), many Hebrew manuscripts, and the ancient versions read "they."
- b (5:2) The Qumran scroll 4QJosh-a (about 150–50 B.C.) is arranged differently here. In it, the end of the account of the reading of the Law (8:34–35) comes right before this verse, linked by a transitional sentence not found in other witnesses. In that order, the covenant reading, and perhaps the building of the altar, took place at Gilgal right after the Jordan crossing. Josephus (Antiquities 5.16–20) also places an altar soon after the crossing. Compare the note at 8:30.
- c (5:3) Gibeath-haaraloth means "hill of the foreskins."
- d (5:6) In verses 4–6 the Septuagint has a different text. It says that some of those who came out of Egypt had been uncircumcised, and that Israel wandered forty-two years in the wilderness.
- e (5:9) Hebrew galal, which sounds like Gilgal; see the note at 4:19.
- f (5:10) Hebrew "on the fourteenth day of the month," that is, the first month of the spring-start religious calendar (4:19). It was called Abib or Nisan and fell in March–April. The exact correspondence varies from year to year with the lunar calendar.
- g (5:11) The Septuagint lacks "on the day after the Passover."

Chapter 6

1 Now Jericho was shut up tight because of the Israelites. No one went
out and no one came in. 2 Yahweh said to Joshua, "See, I have given
into your hand Jericho and its king, the mighty men of valor. 3 You
are to march around the city, all the men of war, going around the
city once. You are to do this for six days. 4 Seven priests are to carry

seven rams' horn trumpets[a] before the ark; on the seventh day, march around the city seven times, with the priests blowing the trumpets.
5 When they make a long blast with the ram's horn, as soon as you hear the sound of the trumpet, all the people are to shout with a great shout, and the wall of the city will fall down flat,[b] and the people are to go up, each man straight before him."
6 Joshua son of Nun called the priests and told them, "Pick up the ark of the covenant, and have seven priests carry seven rams' horn trumpets in front of Yahweh's ark." 7 He[c] told the people, "Advance, and march around the city, with the armed men going ahead of Yahweh's ark." 8 Just as Joshua had spoken to the people, the seven priests carrying the seven trumpets of rams' horns before Yahweh went forward and blew the trumpets, with the ark of the covenant of Yahweh following them. 9 The armed men went before the priests who blew the trumpets, and the rear guard went after the ark, with the trumpets blowing continually. 10 But Joshua commanded the people, "You are not to shout or let your voice be heard, nor let a word go out of your mouth, until the day I tell you to shout. Then you are to shout." 11 So he had Yahweh's ark carried around the city once. Then they went back into the camp and spent the night there.
12 Joshua rose early in the morning, and the priests took up the ark of Yahweh. 13 The seven priests with the seven rams' horn trumpets walked ahead of Yahweh's ark, blowing the trumpets without stopping, with the armed men in front of them and the rear guard behind the ark, while the trumpets sounded without stopping. 14 On the second day they marched around the city once and returned to the camp. They did this for six days.
15 On the seventh day they rose at daybreak and went around the city in that same fashion seven times; only on that day did they circle it seven times. 16 On the seventh circuit, as the priests blew the trumpets, Joshua told the people, "Shout! Yahweh has given you the city. 17 The city and all that is in it belongs to Yahweh, set apart[d] for destruction. Only Rahab the prostitute will live, along with everyone in the house with her, because she hid the messengers whom we sent. 18 As for you, stay away from what is set apart for destruction, or you will

set it apart and then take some of it, making Israel's camp subject to destruction and bringing trouble[e] on it. 19 But all silver and gold, and vessels of bronze and iron, are holy to Yahweh. They are to go into the treasury of Yahweh." 20 So the people shouted when the trumpets sounded. When they heard the trumpet blast, they gave a great shout, and the wall collapsed where it stood. Then the people went up into the city, each man straight ahead, and took it. 21 They devoted to destruction all that was in the city, both man and woman, young and old, and ox, sheep, and donkey, with the edge of the sword.
22 Joshua instructed the two spies, "Go to that prostitute's house, and from there bring the woman out with everything that is hers, as you swore to her." 23 The young men who had been the spies went in and brought out Rahab, with her father, mother, brothers, and everyone belonging to her; they brought out all her family and placed them outside Israel's camp. 24 They put the city to the torch with all it contained; the silver and gold, however, along with the bronze and iron vessels, they deposited in the treasury of Yahweh's house. 25 Joshua spared Rahab the prostitute, her father's household, and everyone belonging to her. She has lived among the Israelites to this day, because she hid the messengers Joshua sent to spy out Jericho.
26 At that time Joshua put them under an oath: "Cursed before Yahweh is the man who gets up and builds this city, Jericho. He will lay its foundation at the cost of his firstborn, and set up its gates at the price of his youngest."[f] 27 So Yahweh was with Joshua, and his fame was in all the land.

Notes

- a (6:4) Hebrew shofarot hayyovelim, "ram's-horn trumpets"; the word yovel, "ram," also gave its name to the Jubilee (Leviticus 25).
- b (6:5) Literally "will fall in its place."
- c (6:7) So the qere (the reading tradition), the Septuagint, and other witnesses. The Hebrew written text (ketiv) reads "They."
- d (6:17) Hebrew ḥerem, something given over completely to Yahweh, which could not be used by people. In war this usually meant its total destruction; so throughout this book.
- e (6:18) Hebrew ʿakhar, "trouble"; compare the Valley of Achor in 7:26.

- f (6:26) The Septuagint adds, “And so did Hozan of Bethel. He laid its foundation with Abiron his firstborn, and set up its gates with his youngest surviving son.” Compare the fulfillment in 1 Kings 16:34, where the builder is Hiel of Bethel and his sons are Abiram and Segub.

Chapter 7

1 But the Israelites acted unfaithfully in regard to the devoted things,
for Achan[a] the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi,[b] the son of Zerah, of
the tribe of Judah, took some of the devoted things. And the anger of
Yahweh burned against the Israelites.
2 Joshua sent men from Jericho to Ai,[c] which is near Beth-aven,[d] east
of Bethel,[e] and said to them, “Go up and spy out the land.” So the men
went up and spied out Ai. 3 They went back to Joshua and told him,
“There is no need for all the people to go up. Send up two or three
thousand men to attack Ai. Do not wear out all the people by sending
them there, for the people of Ai are few.” 4 So some three thousand of
the people went up, but they ran from the men of Ai. 5 The men of Ai
struck down about thirty-six of them, and chased them from before
the gate as far as Shebarim,[f] and struck them down on the descent.
And the hearts of the people melted and became like water.
6 Then Joshua tore his clothes and fell on his face to the earth before
the ark of Yahweh until the evening, he and the elders of Israel, and
they put dust on their heads. 7 Joshua said, “Alas, Lord Yahweh, why
have you brought this people over the Jordan at all, to give us into
the hand of the Amorites, to destroy us? If only we had been content
to dwell beyond the Jordan! 8 O Lord, what can I say, now that Israel
has turned their backs before their enemies? 9 For the Canaanites and
all the inhabitants of the land will hear of it, and will surround us
and cut off our name from the earth. And what will you do for your
great name?”
10 Yahweh said to Joshua, “Get up! Why have you fallen on your face?
11 Israel has sinned! They have violated the covenant I laid on them;
they have taken some of the things set apart for destruction, and they
have stolen, lied, and hidden them among their own possessions. 12
Therefore the Israelites cannot stand before their enemies. They turn
their backs before their enemies, because they have become devoted

to destruction. I will not be with you anymore unless you destroy the devoted things from among you. 13 Rise, consecrate the people, and tell them, 'Consecrate yourselves for tomorrow, because Yahweh, the God of Israel, says this: "Things set apart for destruction are among you, Israel. You will be unable to stand against your enemies until you remove those things from your midst." 14 In the morning you are to come near by your tribes. The tribe that Yahweh takes[g] is to come near by clans, the clan that Yahweh takes is to come near by households, and the household that Yahweh takes is to come near man by man. 15 Whoever is found with the things set apart for destruction shall be burned with fire, along with all he owns, because he broke the covenant of Yahweh and did a disgraceful thing[h] in Israel.'"

16 Joshua got up early the next morning and had the tribes of Israel step forward one at a time, and the tribe of Judah was taken. 17 He had the clans of Judah come forward, and the Zerahite clan was taken. Then he had the Zerahite clan come forward man by man,[i] and Zabdi was taken. 18 He brought near his household man by man, and Achan the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah, was taken. 19 Then Joshua said to Achan, "My son, give glory to Yahweh, the God of Israel, and give praise to him.[j] Tell me now what you have done. Do not hide it from me." 20 Achan answered Joshua, "Truly I have sinned against Yahweh, the God of Israel, and this is what I did: 21 Among the plunder I saw a lovely robe from Shinar,[k] about 5 pounds of silver,[l] and a bar of gold of about 20 ounces,[m] and I wanted them, so I took them. Look, they are buried in the ground inside my tent, with the silver under it."

22 So Joshua sent messengers, and they ran to the tent, and there it was, hidden in his tent with the silver underneath. 23 They took them from the middle of the tent and brought them to Joshua and to all the Israelites, and they laid them out before Yahweh. 24 Then Joshua, and all Israel with him, took Achan the son of Zerah, and the silver, the cloak, the bar of gold, his sons, his daughters, his oxen, his donkeys, his sheep, his tent, and all that he had, and they brought them up to the Valley of Achor. 25 Joshua said, "Why did you bring trouble on us? Today Yahweh brings trouble on you." Then all Israel pelted him with

stones; they burned the rest in the fire and pelted them with stones. 26 Over him they piled a great heap of stones, which is still there today. Then Yahweh turned back from the fierceness of his anger. For this reason that place has been called the Valley of Achor[n] to this day.

Notes

- a (7:1) The Septuagint and 1 Chronicles 2:7 call him Achar, "trouble," which makes a wordplay with the Valley of Achor (verses 25–26).
- b (7:1) The Septuagint has Zambri; 1 Chronicles 2:6 has Zimri.
- c (7:2) Ai (Hebrew haʿai, always with the article) means "the ruin" or "the heap."
- d (7:2) Beth-aven means "house of wickedness" (or "of nothingness"). Hosea 4:15 later uses the name mockingly for Bethel.
- e (7:2) Bethel means "house of God" (Genesis 28:19).
- f (7:5) Or "the quarries"; the Hebrew word means "breakings."
- g (7:14) That is, the tribe that is selected, probably by casting the lot.
- h (7:15) Or "a disgraceful folly" (Hebrew nevalah).
- i (7:17) Some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac read "by households," as in verse 14.
- j (7:19) Or "and make confession to him." This was a formula calling someone to tell the truth under oath (compare John 9:24).
- k (7:21) That is, Babylonia. The Septuagint reads "an embroidered cloak."
- l (7:21) Hebrew "200 shekels," about 2.3 kilograms.
- m (7:21) Hebrew "50 shekels," about 575 grams. Literally "a tongue of gold," that is, a wedge-shaped ingot.
- n (7:26) Achor means "trouble." Compare Hosea 2:15 and Isaiah 65:10, where the valley becomes a place of hope.

Chapter 8

1 Yahweh said to Joshua, "Do not be afraid or discouraged. Take the whole army with you and go up to Ai. Look, I have handed over to you the king of Ai, his people, his city, and his land. 2 Do to Ai and its king what you did to Jericho and its king; but you may keep its plunder and livestock for yourselves. Set an ambush behind the city." 3 So Joshua and all the men of war arose to go up to Ai. Joshua chose thirty thousand mighty men of valor and sent them out by night. 4 He commanded them, "Listen, you are to lie in wait behind the city; do not go very far from it, and all of you stay ready. 5 I and all the people who are with me will approach the city. When they come out against us as at the first, we will flee before them. 6 They will come

out after us until we have lured them away from the city, for they will say, 'They are running from us, as before.' So we will run from them. 7 Then you are to rise up from the ambush and seize the city, for Yahweh your God will give it into your hand. 8 When you have taken the city, you are to set the city on fire. You are to do according to the word of Yahweh. See, I have commanded you." 9 So Joshua sent them out, and they went to the place of ambush and stayed between Bethel and Ai, west of Ai. But Joshua spent that night among the people.
10 Early in the morning Joshua assembled the people, and he and the elders of Israel went up ahead of them to Ai. 11 All the men of war who were with him went up and drew near and came before the city, and they camped north of Ai, with the valley between them and Ai.
12 He took about five thousand men and set them in ambush between Bethel and Ai, west of the city. 13 So the people took their positions, the main camp north of the city and its rear guard to the west. And that night Joshua went into the middle of the valley.[a] 14 When the king of Ai saw this, he and his whole people, the men of the city, hurried and got up early to meet Israel in battle at the appointed place[b] facing the Arabah; but he did not know that an ambush lay behind the city. 15 Joshua and all Israel let themselves be beaten before them and fled by the way of the wilderness. 16 All the people in the city[c] were summoned to chase after them, and as they chased Joshua they were lured away from the city. 17 Not a man was left in Ai or Bethel[d] who did not go out after Israel. They left the city open and pursued Israel.
18 Yahweh then said to Joshua, "Hold out toward Ai the javelin[e] in your hand, for I am giving it into your hand." So Joshua held out toward the city the javelin in his hand. 19 As soon as he stretched out his hand, the men in ambush sprang up from their place and ran. They went into the city, took it, and quickly set it on fire. 20 The men of Ai turned and looked behind them, and saw the city's smoke rising to the sky; they had no strength to run either way, for the people who had been fleeing toward the wilderness turned on those chasing them. 21 Joshua and all Israel saw that the ambush had taken the city and that smoke was rising from it, so they turned around and attacked the men of Ai. 22 The others from the city came out to meet them, so that the

men of Ai were caught in the middle of Israel, with some on one side and some on the other. Israel cut them down until no one was left alive or escaped. 23 But the king of Ai they took alive and brought him to Joshua.

24 When Israel had finished killing all the people of Ai in the open fields and the wilderness where they had chased them, and every one of them had fallen by the sword to the last man, all Israel went back to Ai and put it to the sword. 25 All who fell that day, both men and women, were twelve thousand, all the people of Ai. 26 For Joshua did not pull back the hand that held out the javelin until he had set apart all who lived in Ai for destruction.[f] 27 Only the livestock and the spoil of that city Israel took as plunder for themselves, according to the word of Yahweh that he commanded Joshua. 28 Joshua burned Ai and made it a mound[g] forever, a waste to this day. 29 He hung the king of Ai on a tree until evening, and at sunset Joshua gave the order, and they took his body down from the tree and threw it at the entrance of the city gate. Over it they raised a large pile of stones, which is still there.

30 Then Joshua built an altar[h] to Yahweh, the God of Israel, on Mount Ebal,[i] 31 just as Moses, Yahweh's servant, had commanded the Israelites and as it is written in the book of the law of Moses: an altar of uncut stones that no iron tool had touched. On it they offered burnt offerings to Yahweh and sacrificed peace offerings. 32 There, in the presence of the Israelites, he wrote on the stones a copy of the law of Moses, which he had written. 33 All Israel—the foreign resident as well as the native-born—with their elders, officers, and judges, stood on both sides of the ark facing the Levitical priests who carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh, half toward Mount Gerizim[j] and half toward Mount Ebal, as Moses the servant of Yahweh had earlier commanded for blessing the people of Israel. 34 Afterward he read all the words of the law, the blessing and the curse, according to all that is written in the book of the law. 35 Of everything Moses had commanded, there was not a word that Joshua failed to read before the entire assembly of Israel, including the women, the little children, and the foreign residents living among them.

Notes

- a (8:13) Some Hebrew manuscripts read "spent that night" (compare verse 9). The Septuagint lacks most of verses 11b–13; it does not mention the second ambush of five thousand men.
- b (8:14) Hebrew mo'ed; or, with a small change, "at the descent." The Septuagint lacks this phrase.
- c (8:16) The Hebrew written text (ketiv) reads "in the city"; the qere (the reading tradition) reads "in Ai."
- d (8:17) The Septuagint lacks "or Bethel."
- e (8:18) Or "scimitar" (Hebrew kidon); a curved sword is possible. The Septuagint reads "spear."
- f (8:26) The Septuagint lacks this verse.
- g (8:28) Hebrew tel, a mound of ruins, the word that gave its name to the archaeological "tell." The name Ai means "the ruin" (see the note at 7:2).
- h (8:30) The Hebrew text places the altar and the covenant reading on Mount Ebal (verses 30–35) here. The Septuagint places them after 9:2. The Qumran scroll 4QJosh-a apparently placed at least the reading of the Law (verses 34–35) right after the Jordan crossing, before 5:2 (see the note there). These different placements suggest that the passage was positioned differently in different early forms of the text. Compare Deuteronomy 11:29; 27:1–26.
- i (8:30) Ebal may mean "bare" or "stony." Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim stand on either side of Shechem.
- j (8:33) Gerizim may mean "those cut off." The Samaritans later regarded it as the chosen place of worship (compare John 4:20).

Chapter 9

1 When all the kings west of the Jordan heard about this—those in
the hill country, the lowland,[a] and along the whole coast of the Great
Sea toward Lebanon: the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites,
Hivites, and Jebusites— 2 they gathered together with one accord to
fight against Joshua and Israel.[b]
3 But when the inhabitants of Gibeon[c] heard what Joshua had done to
Jericho and to Ai, 4 they also acted craftily. They went and disguised
themselves as envoys,[d] and took worn-out sacks for their donkeys,
and wineskins that were worn-out, torn, and mended, 5 with worn-
out, patched sandals on their feet and worn-out clothes on them. And
all the bread of their provisions was dry and crumbly. 6 They went
to Joshua at the camp at Gilgal and said to him and to the men of
Israel, "We have come from a distant country. Now therefore make a

covenant with us." 7 The men of Israel replied to the Hivites, "Maybe
you live among us; how then could we make a covenant with you?"
8 They told Joshua, "We are your servants." But Joshua demanded,
"Who are you, and from where have you come?" 9 They answered,
"Your servants have come from a very distant country because of the
name of Yahweh your God, for we have heard news of him, and of all
he did in Egypt, 10 and all that he did to the two kings of the Amorites
who were beyond the Jordan, to Sihon king of Heshbon and to Og
king of Bashan, who was at Ashtaroth. 11 So our elders and everyone
living in our land told us, 'Take provisions for the journey, go meet
them, and tell them: "We are your servants; so now make a covenant
with us."' 12 This bread of ours was still warm when we took it from
our houses as food for the journey on the day we left to come to you;
but now look, it is dry and crumbling. 13 These wineskins were new
when we filled them, and see, they are torn. And these clothes and
sandals of ours are worn out from the very long journey." 14 So the
men took some of their provisions, but they did not ask counsel from
the mouth of Yahweh. 15 Joshua made peace with them and made a
covenant with them, to let them live, and the leaders of the congre-
gation swore an oath to them.
16 At the end of three days after they had made a covenant with
them, they heard that they were their neighbors and that they lived
among them. 17 So the Israelites set out and came to their cities on the
third day. Their cities were Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-
jearim.[e] 18 But the Israelites did not strike them, because the leaders
of the congregation had sworn to them by Yahweh, the God of Israel.
Then all the congregation grumbled against the leaders. 19 But all
the leaders said to all the congregation, "We have sworn to them by
Yahweh, the God of Israel, and now we cannot touch them. 20 This is
what we will do: we will let them live, so that no wrath will fall on
us because of the oath we swore to them." 21 The leaders added, "Let
them live." So they became woodcutters and water carriers for the
whole congregation, as the leaders had decided concerning them.
22 Joshua called them and said, "Why did you trick us by saying, 'We
live very far from you,' when you actually live among us? 23 Now

therefore you are cursed, and some of you will never cease to be slaves, cutters of wood and drawers of water for the house of my God." 24 They answered Joshua, "Because it was clearly told to your servants that Yahweh your God had commanded his servant Moses to give you all the land and to destroy all the inhabitants of the land before you, we feared greatly for our lives because of you and did this thing. 25 Now, see, we are in your hand. Do to us whatever seems good and right in your sight." 26 So he did this to them: he delivered them out of the hand of the Israelites, and they did not kill them. 27 That day Joshua made them cutters of wood and drawers of water for the congregation and for the altar of Yahweh, to this day, at the place that he would choose.

Notes

- a (9:1) Hebrew shephelah, the low foothills between the hill country of Judah and the coastal plain.
- b (9:2) Here the Septuagint has the account of the altar on Mount Ebal and the reading of the Law (Hebrew 8:30–35), as 9:2a–f. In it the passage begins, "Then Joshua built an altar to the Lord, the God of Israel, on Mount Gaibal." See the note at 8:30.
- c (9:3) Gibeon means "hill" or "hilltop place" (from giv'ah, "hill"). It is probably el-Jib, about 6 miles (10 kilometers) northwest of Jerusalem.
- d (9:4) The Hebrew word is uncertain. With a one-letter difference, some Hebrew manuscripts and the ancient versions read "they took provisions" (compare verse 12). The Septuagint reads "they made provision and prepared themselves."
- e (9:17) Kiriath-jearim means "city of forests." Beeroth means "wells," and Chephirah may mean "village" or "lioness."

Chapter 10

1 When Adoni-zedek[a] king of Jerusalem[b] heard that Joshua had captured Ai and devoted it to destruction, doing to Ai and its king as he had done to Jericho and its king, and that the inhabitants of Gibeon had made peace with Israel and were among them, 2 he[c] feared greatly, because Gibeon was a great city, like one of the royal cities, and because it was greater than Ai, and all its men were mighty. 3 Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem sent word to Hoham king of Hebron,[d] Piram king of Jarmuth, Japhia king of Lachish, and Debir king of Eglon,[e] saying, 4 "Come up and help me attack Gibeon, because it has made

peace with Joshua and the Israelites." 5 So the five Amorite kings—
the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon—joined
forces and marched up with all their armies; they camped by Gibeon
and attacked it.
6 The men of Gibeon sent to Joshua at the camp at Gilgal, saying, "Do
not withdraw your hand from your servants. Come up to us quickly
and save us and help us, for all the kings of the Amorites who live
in the hill country have gathered against us." 7 So Joshua went up
from Gilgal, he and all the people of war with him, and all the mighty
men of valor. 8 Yahweh said to Joshua, "Do not fear them, for I have
given them into your hand. Not a man of them will stand before you."
9 Joshua came against them suddenly, after marching all night from
Gilgal. 10 Yahweh threw them into a panic before Israel, and he[f] struck
them with a great slaughter at Gibeon and chased them by the way
of the ascent of Beth-horon,[g] and struck them as far as Azekah and
Makkedah. 11 As they ran from Israel down the slope of Beth-horon,
Yahweh hurled huge stones from the sky on them all the way to
Azekah, and they died; the hailstones killed more of them than the
Israelites killed with the sword.
12 Then Joshua spoke to Yahweh on the day when Yahweh gave the
Amorites over to the Israelites, and he said in the sight of Israel,[h] "Sun,
be still[i] at Gibeon, and moon, in the Valley of Aijalon."[j] 13 And the sun
stood still, and the moon stopped, until the nation took vengeance
on its enemies. Is this not written in the Book of Jashar?[k] The sun
stopped in the middle of the heavens and did not hurry to go down
for about a whole day.[l] 14 There has never been a day like it, before
or since, when Yahweh heeded the voice of a man; for Yahweh was
fighting for Israel.
15 Then Joshua returned, and all Israel with him, to the camp at Gilgal.[m]
16 These five kings fled and hid themselves in the cave at Makkedah.
17 It was told to Joshua, "The five kings have been found, hidden in
the cave at Makkedah." 18 Joshua said, "Roll great stones against the
mouth of the cave and set men by it to guard them. 19 But do not stop
there. Chase your enemies and attack them from behind; do not let
them reach their cities, for Yahweh your God has handed them over

to you." 20 When Joshua and the Israelites had finished a very great slaughter of them, until they were finished off, and the survivors had reached their fortified cities, 21 all the people returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah. No one moved his tongue against any of the Israelites.
22 Then Joshua said, "Open the mouth of the cave and bring out to me these five kings from the cave." 23 They did so and brought out to him these five kings from the cave: the king of Jerusalem, the king of Hebron, the king of Jarmuth, the king of Lachish, and the king of Eglon. 24 When they brought these kings out to Joshua, Joshua summoned all the men of Israel and said to the chiefs of the men of war who had gone with him, "Come near, put your feet on the necks of these kings." So they came near and put their feet on their necks.
25 Joshua told them, "Do not be afraid or discouraged; be strong and courageous. This is what Yahweh will do to all the enemies you fight."
26 After that Joshua killed them and hung them on five trees, and they remained hanging there until evening. 27 As the sun was setting Joshua gave a command, and they lowered them from the trees and threw them into the cave in which they had hidden; over its mouth they placed great stones, which remain to this very day.
28 Joshua captured Makkedah that day, put it and its king to the sword, and set every person in it apart for destruction, leaving no survivor. The king of Makkedah he treated just like the king of Jericho.
29 Then Joshua and all Israel with him passed on from Makkedah to Libnah and fought against Libnah. 30 Yahweh also gave it and its king into Israel's hand. Joshua put it to the sword along with everyone in it, leaving no survivor there, and he treated its king as he had treated the king of Jericho.
31 Then Joshua and all Israel with him passed on from Libnah to Lachish, and camped against it and fought against it. 32 Yahweh handed Lachish over to Israel, who captured it on the second day and put it and everyone in it to the sword, just as he had done to Libnah.
33 Then Horam king of Gezer came up to help Lachish, and Joshua struck him and his people until he left him no survivor.

34 Then Joshua and all Israel with him passed on from Lachish to
Eglon, and they camped against it and fought against it. 35 On that day
they took it and killed everyone in it with the sword; he set every
person in it apart for destruction that day, as he had done to Lachish.
36 Then Joshua and all Israel with him went up from Eglon to Hebron,
and they fought against it. 37 They captured it and put it, its king, its
towns, and everyone in it to the sword; he left no survivor, just as at
Eglon, and set it and every person in it apart for destruction.
38 Then Joshua and all Israel with him turned back to Debir[n] and
attacked it. 39 He captured it, its king, and all its towns, put them to
the sword, and set every person in it apart for destruction, leaving no
survivor. What he had done to Hebron, and to Libnah and its king,
he did to Debir and its king.
40 So Joshua struck the whole land, the hill country, the Negev,[o] the
lowland, and the slopes, and all their kings. He left no survivor, but
devoted to destruction all that breathed, as Yahweh, the God of Israel,
commanded. 41 Joshua conquered them from Kadesh-barnea[p] to Gaza,
and the whole region of Goshen up to Gibeon. 42 Joshua captured all
these kings and their land at one time, because Yahweh, the God of
Israel, fought for Israel. 43 Then Joshua returned, and all Israel with
him, to the camp at Gilgal.

Notes

- a (10:1) Adoni-zedek means "my lord is righteous" (or "my lord is Zedek," a divine name). Compare Melchizedek, king of Salem (Genesis 14:18). The Septuagint reads Adonibezek (compare Judges 1:5–7).
- b (10:1) The meaning of Jerusalem is uncertain; it is perhaps "foundation of Shalem," the name of a god, though it was later understood as "city of peace."
- c (10:2) Hebrew "they."
- d (10:3) Hebron may mean "alliance" or "association." It was earlier called Kiriath-arba (14:15).
- e (10:3) The Septuagint reads "Dabin king of Odollam" (that is, Adullam) here and in verses 5 and 23, though it has Eglon in verses 34–37.
- f (10:10) That is, Joshua (or Israel).
- g (10:10) Beth-horon probably means "house of Horon," a Canaanite god, or perhaps "house of the hollow." The road climbed from the coastal lowland through Upper and Lower Beth-horon.

- h (10:12) The Hebrew can also mean “and he said, in the sight of Israel.” The Septuagint reads only “and Joshua said.”
- i (10:12) Hebrew dom, “be still, be silent,” or “stop.” Some interpreters take the poetry as a request that the sun stop shining (cease its scorching heat, or be darkened by the storm of verse 11) rather than stop moving. The lines are poetry, and the prose that follows takes them literally.
- j (10:12) Aijalon means “place of deer” (from ’ayyal, “deer”). The valley lies west of Gibeon, so the sun stood over Gibeon to the east and the moon over Aijalon to the west, which may suggest an early morning scene.
- k (10:13) Jashar means “the upright one.” The Book of Jashar was an early collection of poetry, now lost, that is also cited in 2 Samuel 1:18 (David’s lament). The Septuagint lacks the question “Is this not written in the Book of Jashar?” here. The Septuagint of 1 Kings 8:53 cites a “book of song,” which may be the same work under a slightly different name.
- l (10:13) Literally “as a complete day” (Hebrew keyom tamim). The time is not given in hours.
- m (10:15) The Septuagint lacks this verse, which anticipates verse 43; verse 21 places the camp at Makkedah.
- n (10:38) Debir means “back room” or “inner sanctuary.” It was earlier called Kiriath-sepher, “city of the book” (15:15).
- o (10:40) Negev means “dry land,” the arid region in the south of Judah.
- p (10:41) Kadesh-barnea means “holy place of Barnea”; it was the main oasis of the Sinai wanderings (Numbers 13:26; 32:8).

Chapter 11

1 Jabin[a] king of Hazor[b] heard of these events and sent messages to
Jobab king of Madon, to the king of Shimron, and to the king of
Achshaph, 2 and the kings in the northern hill country, in the Arabah
south of Chinneroth,[c] in the lowland, and in Naphoth-dor[d] to the
west, 3 the Canaanites to the east and west, the Amorites, Hittites,
Perizzites, and Jebusites in the hill country, and the Hivites at the foot
of Hermon in the land of Mizpah.[e] 4 They came out, they and all their
armies with them, a great people, as many as the sand that is on the
seashore, with very many horses and chariots. 5 All these kings met
by appointment, and they came and camped together at the waters
of Merom[f] to fight against Israel.
6 Yahweh told Joshua, “Do not fear them; about this time tomorrow I
will hand them all over to Israel, killed. You are to cut the hamstrings
of their horses and burn their chariots in the fire.” 7 So Joshua and all

his fighting men came against them suddenly at the waters of Merom and attacked them. 8 Yahweh handed them over to Israel, who defeated them and pursued them to Great Sidon, to Misrephoth-maim,[g] and east to the Valley of Mizpeh, striking them down until none were left. 9 Joshua did to them as Yahweh told him. He hamstrung their horses and burned their chariots with fire.

10 At that time Joshua turned back, captured Hazor, and killed its king with the sword; Hazor had formerly been the head of all those kingdoms. 11 They put to the sword every person in it, setting them apart for destruction; nothing that breathed remained, and Hazor itself he burned with fire. 12 Joshua captured all the cities of those kings, and all their kings, and put them to the sword, setting them apart for destruction, as Moses the servant of Yahweh had commanded. 13 Yet Israel burned none of the cities standing on their mounds,[h] apart from Hazor alone, which Joshua burned. 14 The Israelites took for themselves all the plunder of these cities, and the livestock; but they put every person to the sword until they had wiped them out, leaving no one alive who breathed. 15 Just as Yahweh had commanded Moses his servant, so Moses commanded Joshua, and so Joshua did. He left nothing undone of all that Yahweh had commanded Moses.

16 So Joshua took all that land, the hill country, all the Negev, all the land of Goshen, the lowland, the Arabah, and the hill country of Israel and its lowland, 17 from Mount Halak,[i] which rises toward Seir, all the way to Baal-gad[j] in the Valley of Lebanon at the foot of Mount Hermon. He captured all their kings, struck them down, and put them to death. 18 Joshua made war a long time with all those kings. 19 There was not a city that made peace with the Israelites except the Hivites, the inhabitants of Gibeon. They took them all in battle. 20 For it was Yahweh's doing to harden their hearts so that they would meet Israel in battle, and so be set apart for destruction without mercy, being wiped out as Yahweh had commanded Moses.

21 Joshua went at that time and eliminated the Anakim[k] who lived in the hill country—in Hebron, Debir, and Anab, and in the entire hill country of Judah and of Israel; he set them apart for destruction along with their cities. 22 There were no Anakim left in the land of the

Israelites. Only in Gaza, in Gath, and in Ashdod did some remain. 23 Thus Joshua took the entire land, just as Yahweh had told Moses, and gave it to Israel as an inheritance, divided among their tribes. Then the land had rest from war.

Notes

- a (11:1) Jabin may mean "he understands" or "he discerns." A later Jabin king of Hazor appears in Judges 4.
- b (11:1) Hazor probably means "enclosure" or "settlement." It was the largest city of Canaan, north of the Sea of Galilee.
- c (11:2) That is, the Sea of Galilee; Chinnereth may mean "harp-shaped."
- d (11:2) Or "the heights of Dor," a coastal town south of Mount Carmel.
- e (11:3) Mizpah means "watchtower" or "lookout"; so also Mizpeh in verse 8.
- f (11:5) Merom means "height."
- g (11:8) Misrephoth-maim may mean "burnings at the water" (perhaps lime kilns or salt pans), or "hot springs."
- h (11:13) Hebrew tel; see the note at 8:28.
- i (11:17) Halak means "smooth" or "bare."
- j (11:17) Baal-gad means "lord of fortune," or "Baal of Gad" (a god of luck).
- k (11:21) Anakim probably means "people of the neck," that is, long-necked or tall. They were remembered as giants (Numbers 13:33; Deuteronomy 2:10–11).

Chapter 12

1 These are the kings of the land whom the Israelites defeated and whose territory they took across the Jordan to the east, from the Arnon Valley to Mount Hermon, including the whole eastern Arabah: 2 Sihon king of the Amorites, who lived at Heshbon and ruled from Aroer, which is on the edge of the valley of the Arnon, and from the middle of the valley, and half of Gilead, as far as the river Jabbok, the border of the Ammonites, 3 and the Arabah as far as the Sea of Chinneroth eastward, and as far as the Sea of the Arabah, the Salt Sea, eastward toward Beth-jeshimoth, and on the south below the slopes of Pisgah;[a] 4 and the territory of Og king of Bashan, one of the remnant of the Rephaim,[b] who lived at Ashtaroth and at Edrei 5 and ruled in Mount Hermon, in Salecah, and in the whole of Bashan, to the territory of the Geshurites and the Maacathites, and over the half of Gilead reaching the border of Sihon, king of Heshbon. 6 Moses the servant of Yahweh and the Israelites struck them, and Moses

the servant of Yahweh gave it as a possession to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.
7 These are the kings of the land that Joshua and the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan, from Baal-gad in the Valley of Lebanon as far as Mount Halak, which rises toward Seir. Joshua then gave their land to Israel's tribes as a possession, divided into portions, 8 in the hill country and the lowland, the Arabah and the slopes, the wilderness and the Negev: the land of the Hittites and the Amorites, the Canaanites and the Perizzites, the Hivites and the Jebusites: 9 the king of Jericho, one; the king of Ai, which is beside Bethel, one; 10 the king of Jerusalem, one; the king of Hebron, one; 11 the king of Jarmuth, one; the king of Lachish, one; 12 the king of Eglon, one; the king of Gezer, one; 13 the king of Debir, one; the king of Geder, one; 14 the king of Hormah,[c] one; the king of Arad, one; 15 the king of Libnah, one; the king of Adullam, one; 16 the king of Makkedah, one; the king of Bethel, one; 17 the king of Tappuah, one; the king of Hepher, one; 18 the king of Aphek, one; the king of Lasharon, one;[d] 19 the king of Madon, one; the king of Hazor, one; 20 the king of Shimron-meron, one; the king of Achshaph, one; 21 the king of Taanach, one; the king of Megiddo, one; 22 the king of Kedesh, one; the king of Jokneam in Carmel, one; 23 the king of Dor in Naphath-dor, one; the king of Goiim[e] in Gilgal, one; 24 the king of Tirzah, one: in all, thirty-one kings.[f]

Notes

- a (12:3) Pisgah means "cleft" or "peak." From its summit Moses viewed the land (Deuteronomy 34:1).
- b (12:4) The Rephaim were an ancient people remembered as giants (Deuteronomy 3:11). The word is also used for the shades of the dead.
- c (12:14) Hormah means "devotion to destruction" (from ḥaram; Numbers 21:3).
- d (12:18) Or "the king of Aphek in Sharon." The Septuagint reads "the king of Ophek of Aroc."
- e (12:23) Goiim means "nations." The Septuagint reads "Gei of Galilee," which suits the northern setting (compare Isaiah 9:1).
- f (12:24) The Septuagint lists twenty-nine kings, with differences in several names.

Chapter 13

1 Joshua was now old, well along in years, and Yahweh said to him, "You have grown old and are well along in years, yet a great deal of

the land is still to be taken. 2 This is the land that still remains: all
the regions of the Philistines and all those of the Geshurites 3 (from
the Shihor,[a] east of Egypt, north to the boundary of Ekron, counted
as Canaanite; the five rulers[b] of the Philistines were those of Gaza,
Ashdod, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron), and the Avvim 4 in the south;
all the land of the Canaanites, and Mearah that belongs to the Sido-
nians, as far as Aphek, to the border of the Amorites; 5 and the land
of the Gebalites,[c] and all Lebanon toward the sunrise, from Baal-gad
below Mount Hermon to Lebo-hamath.[d] 6 All the inhabitants of the
hill country from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim, all the Sidonians, I
myself will drive them out from before the Israelites. Only allot it to
Israel for an inheritance, as I have commanded you. 7 Now therefore
divide this land for an inheritance to the nine tribes and the half-tribe
of Manasseh."
8 Together with the other half of Manasseh,[e] the Reubenites and
Gadites received the inheritance Moses gave them east of the Jordan,
just as Moses the servant of Yahweh had given it to them: 9 from
Aroer, which sits on the rim of the Arnon gorge, and from the city in
the gorge's middle, with the entire tableland[f] from Medeba to Dibon,
10 and all the cities of Sihon king of the Amorites, who reigned in
Heshbon, as far as the border of the Ammonites, 11 and Gilead, and the
territory of the Geshurites and Maacathites, and all Mount Hermon,
and all Bashan as far as Salecah, 12 the whole realm of Og in Bashan,
who had reigned at Ashtaroth and at Edrei; he alone remained of
the remnant of the Rephaim. Moses had defeated these and driven
them out. 13 But the Israelites did not drive out the Geshurites or the
Maacathites, and Geshur and Maacath live in the midst of Israel to
this day. 14 Only to the tribe of Levi did he give no inheritance; the
fire offerings to Yahweh, the God of Israel, are their inheritance, as
he had told him.[g]
15 To the tribe of the Reubenites, by their clans, Moses gave an inher-
itance. 16 Their territory was from Aroer, which is on the edge of the
valley of the Arnon, and the city that is in the middle of the valley, and
all the tableland by Medeba; 17 Heshbon and all its cities that are in the
tableland: Dibon, Bamoth-baal,[h] Beth-baal-meon, 18 Jahaz, Kedemoth,

Mephaath, 19 Kiriathaim, Sibmah, and Zereth-shahar on the hill of the
valley, 20 Beth-peor, the slopes of Pisgah, and Beth-jeshimoth, 21 all the
cities of the tableland and the whole kingdom of Sihon king of the
Amorites, who ruled in Heshbon, whom Moses defeated along with
the chiefs of Midian—Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba—the princes
of Sihon who lived in the land. 22 Balaam also, the son of Beor, the
diviner, the Israelites killed with the sword among the rest of their
slain. 23 The border of the Reubenites was the Jordan and its region.[i]
This was the inheritance of the Reubenites according to their clans,
the cities with their villages.
24 Moses gave an inheritance to the tribe of Gad, to the Gadites,
according to their clans. 25 Their territory was Jazer and all the cities
of Gilead, and half the land of the Ammonites, as far as Aroer,
which is east of Rabbah, 26 and from Heshbon to Ramath-mizpeh
and Betonim, and from Mahanaim[j] to the territory of Debir,[k] 27 and
in the valley, Beth-haram, Beth-nimrah, Succoth,[l] and Zaphon, the
rest of the kingdom of Sihon king of Heshbon, with the Jordan as
its boundary, as far as the end of the Sea of Chinnereth, beyond the
Jordan eastward. 28 This is the inheritance of the Gadites according to
their clans, the cities with their villages.
29 Moses gave an inheritance to the half-tribe of Manasseh. It was
for the half-tribe of the Manassites according to their clans. 30 Their
territory was from Mahanaim, all Bashan, all the kingdom of Og king
of Bashan, and all Havvoth-jair,[m] which are in Bashan, sixty cities, 31
and half of Gilead, with Ashtaroth and Edrei, cities of the realm of
Og in Bashan. These went to the sons of Machir, Manasseh's son—to
half of Machir's sons, by their clans.
32 These are the inheritances Moses distributed in the plains of Moab,
east of Jericho across the Jordan. 33 But to the tribe of Levi Moses gave
no inheritance. Yahweh, the God of Israel, is their inheritance, as he
said to them.[n]

Notes

- a (13:3) Shihor means "black" or "the pool of Horus," probably an eastern branch of the Nile or a stream on Egypt's border.

- b (13:3) Hebrew seren, a Philistine word for the rulers of their five cities; it may be related to Greek tyrannos.
- c (13:5) That is, the people of Gebal (Byblos), on the coast north of Beirut.
- d (13:5) Or "to the entrance of Hamath."
- e (13:8) Hebrew "With it," referring back to the half-tribe of Manasseh in verse 7.
- f (13:9) Hebrew mishor, "level land," the plateau east of the Dead Sea; so throughout this chapter.
- g (13:14) The Septuagint adds, "This is the division that Moses made for the Israelites in the plains of Moab, beyond the Jordan, by Jericho" (compare verse 32).
- h (13:17) Bamoth-baal means "high places of Baal."
- i (13:23) Or "The border of the Reubenites was the Jordan, as a boundary."
- j (13:26) Mahanaim means "two camps" (Genesis 32:2).
- k (13:26) Hebrew Lidbir, perhaps the same as Lo-debar (2 Samuel 9:4).
- l (13:27) Succoth means "booths" (Genesis 33:17).
- m (13:30) Havvoth-jair means "tent villages of Jair" (Numbers 32:41).
- n (13:33) The Septuagint lacks this verse.

Chapter 14

1 These are the inheritances the Israelites received in the land of
Canaan, which Eleazar[a] the priest, Joshua son of Nun, and the heads
of the families of the Israelite tribes distributed to them. 2 Their inher-
itance was by lot, as Yahweh had commanded through Moses, for the
nine tribes and the half-tribe. 3 For Moses had given the inheritance
of the two and a half tribes beyond the Jordan, but to the Levites
he gave no inheritance among them. 4 For the descendants of Joseph
formed two tribes, Manasseh and Ephraim. The Levites received no
share in the land except cities to live in, along with pastureland for
their livestock and goods. 5 The Israelites did as Yahweh commanded
Moses, and they divided the land.
6 Then the people of Judah came to Joshua at Gilgal. Caleb[b] the son of
Jephunneh the Kenizzite[c] said to him, "You know what Yahweh said
to Moses the man of God at Kadesh-barnea concerning you and me. 7 I
was forty years old when Moses the servant of Yahweh sent me from
Kadesh-barnea to scout the land, and I reported to him what was in
my heart. 8 But my brothers who went up with me made the heart
of the people melt, while I wholly followed Yahweh my God. 9 On
that day Moses swore, 'The land your foot has walked on will surely
be your inheritance and your children's forever, because you have

followed Yahweh my God fully.' [10] And now, see, Yahweh has kept me alive, as he said, these forty-five years since the time that Yahweh spoke this word to Moses, while Israel walked in the wilderness. And now, see, I am today eighty-five years old. [11] I am as strong today as on the day Moses sent me; my strength now equals my strength then, for fighting and for going out and coming in. [12] So now give me this hill country about which Yahweh spoke that day, since you heard then that the Anakim were there, in great fortified cities. Perhaps Yahweh will be with me and I will drive them out, as Yahweh said."
[13] Then Joshua blessed him, and he gave Hebron to Caleb the son of Jephunneh for an inheritance. [14] Therefore Hebron became the inheritance of Caleb the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite to this day, because he wholly followed Yahweh, the God of Israel. [15] Hebron's name was formerly Kiriath-arba;[d] Arba[e] was the greatest man among the Anakim. Then the land had rest from war.

Notes

- a (14:1) Eleazar means "God has helped."
- b (14:6) Caleb means "dog," perhaps in the sense of a loyal servant. Some connect the name with kol-lev, "whole heart," in light of verses 8–9 and 14.
- c (14:6) The Kenizzites were a clan related to Edom (Genesis 15:19; 36:11). Caleb's family had been joined to the tribe of Judah.
- d (14:15) Kiriath-arba means "city of four" or "city of Arba."
- e (14:15) The Septuagint reads, "The name of Hebron formerly was the city of Argob; it is the mother city of the Anakim."

Chapter 15

[1] The portion for the tribe of Judah, by their clans, extended south to the border of Edom, to the wilderness of Zin at the far south. [2] Their southern border ran from the end of the Salt Sea, from the bay that faces southward. [3] It went out southward of the ascent of Akrabbim,[a] passed along to Zin, went up south of Kadesh-barnea, passed along by Hezron, went up to Addar, and turned about to Karka. [4] It passed along to Azmon, went out by the Brook of Egypt,[b] and the border ended at the sea. This will be your southern border. [5] The eastern boundary was the Salt Sea, as far as the Jordan's mouth. The northern side's border began at the sea's inlet, at the mouth of the Jordan. [6]

The border went up to Beth-hoglah and passed along north of Beth-
arabah. The border went up to the stone of Bohan the son of Reuben.
7 From the Valley of Achor the border went up to Debir and then
north, turning toward Gilgal, which faces the ascent of Adummim,[c]
south of the valley. It continued to the waters of En-shemesh[d] and
ended at En-rogel.[e] 8 Then the border climbed by the Valley of the Son
of Hinnom[f] along the Jebusite's southern ridge (which is Jerusalem).
From there it ran up to the peak of the mountain that stands opposite
the Valley of Hinnom on its west side, at the far north end of the
Valley of Rephaim. 9 Then the border was drawn from the top of the
mountain to the spring of the waters of Nephtoah,[g] went out to the
cities of Mount Ephron, and the border was drawn to Baalah (that is,
Kiriath-jearim). 10 The border turned about from Baalah westward to
Mount Seir, passed along to the northern shoulder of Mount Jearim
(that is, Chesalon), went down to Beth-shemesh,[h] and passed along
by Timnah. 11 The border proceeded to the ridge north of Ekron,
bent around to Shikkeron, went across Mount Baalah, and reached
Jabneel; its end was at the sea. 12 The western border was the Great Sea
with its coastline. This is the border all around the people of Judah
according to their clans.
13 To Caleb the son of Jephunneh he gave a portion among the people
of Judah, according to the command of Yahweh to Joshua, Kiriath-
arba (Arba was the father of Anak), that is, Hebron. 14 Caleb drove out
from there the three sons of Anak, Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai, the
descendants of Anak. 15 He went up from there against the inhabitants
of Debir. Now the name of Debir formerly was Kiriath-sepher.[i] 16 Caleb
said, "To the man who attacks Kiriath-sepher and takes it, I will give
my daughter Achsah[j] as his wife." 17 Othniel[k] son of Kenaz, Caleb's
brother, took it, and Caleb gave him his daughter Achsah as wife. 18
When she arrived, she urged him to ask her father for a field. She
dismounted from her donkey, and Caleb asked her, "What do you
want?" 19 She replied, "Give me a blessing.[l] Since you have given me
land in the Negev, give me springs of water also." So he gave her the
upper and lower springs.

20 This is the inheritance of the tribe of the people of Judah according
to their clans. 21 The cities at the farthest limits of the tribe of the
people of Judah, toward the border of Edom in the Negev, were
Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur, 22 Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah, 23 Kedesh, Hazor,
Ithnan, 24 Ziph, Telem, Bealoth, 25 Hazor-hadattah and Kerioth-hezron
(that is, Hazor), 26 also Amam, Shema, and Moladah, 27 also Hazar-
gaddah, Heshmon, and Beth-pelet, 28 also Hazar-shual, Beersheba,[m]
and Biziothiah, 29 Baalah, Iim, Ezem, 30 Eltolad, Chesil, Hormah, 31 Zik-
lag, Madmannah, Sansannah, 32 Lebaoth, Shilhim, Ain, and Rimmon
—twenty-nine cities in all, with their villages.[n]
33 In the lowland there were Eshtaol, Zorah, and Ashnah, 34 along
with Zanoah, En-gannim, Tappuah, and Enam, 35 also Jarmuth, Adul-
lam, Socoh, and Azekah, 36 and Shaaraim, Adithaim, Gederah, and
Gederothaim—fourteen cities and their villages.
37 Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal-gad, 38 Dilean, Mizpeh, Joktheel, 39 Lachish,
Bozkath, Eglon, 40 Cabbon, Lahmam, Chitlish, 41 Gederoth, Beth-
dagon, Naamah, and Makkedah: sixteen cities with their villages.
42 Libnah, Ether, Ashan, 43 Iphtah, Ashnah, Nezib, 44 Keilah, Achzib, and
Mareshah: nine cities with their villages.
45 Ekron with its towns[o] and its villages; 46 from Ekron to the sea, all
that were by the side of Ashdod, with their villages. 47 Ashdod, with
its towns and villages; Gaza, with its towns and villages, up to the
Brook of Egypt; and the Great Sea with its shore.
48 In the hill country: Shamir, Jattir, Socoh, 49 Dannah, Kiriath-sannah
(that is, Debir), 50 Anab, Eshtemoh, Anim, 51 Goshen, Holon, and Giloh:
eleven cities with their villages.
52 Arab, Dumah, Eshan, 53 Janim, Beth-tappuah, Aphekah, 54 Humtah,
Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron), and Zior—nine cities and their villages.
55 Also Maon, Carmel, Ziph, and Juttah, 56 then Jezreel, Jokdeam, and
Zanoah, 57 Kain, Gibeah, and Timnah—ten cities and their villages.
58 Halhul, Beth-zur, Gedor, 59 Maarath, Beth-anoth, and Eltekon: six
cities with their villages.[p]
60 Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim) and Rabbah: two cities with
their villages.

61 In the wilderness: Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah, 62 Nibshan, the City
of Salt,[q] and En-gedi:[r] six cities with their villages.
63 As for the Jebusites living in Jerusalem, the people of Judah were
unable to drive them out, and so the Jebusites have lived with the
people of Judah in Jerusalem to this day.

Notes

- a (15:3) Akrabbim means "scorpions."
- b (15:4) Hebrew naḥal Mitsrayim, the Wadi el-Arish in northern Sinai.
- c (15:7) Adummim means "red (places)," probably from the red rock along the road from Jericho to Jerusalem.
- d (15:7) En-shemesh means "spring of the sun."
- e (15:7) En-rogel may mean "spring of the fuller" or "spring of the foot."
- f (15:8) Hebrew Ge ben-Hinnom. The Hebrew Ge-Hinnom later became the Greek Gehenna, a name for the place of judgment (Matthew 5:22).
- g (15:9) Or "the spring of Me-nephtoah." Nephtoah may mean "opening."
- h (15:10) Beth-shemesh means "house of the sun."
- i (15:15) Kiriath-sepher means "city of the book" (or "city of the scribe"). The Septuagint reads "city of letters." Verse 49 calls it Kiriath-sannah.
- j (15:16) Achsah means "anklet."
- k (15:17) Othniel may mean "God is my strength" (or "lion of God"). He became Israel's first judge (Judges 3:9–11).
- l (15:19) That is, a gift.
- m (15:28) Beersheba means "well of seven" or "well of the oath" (Genesis 21:31).
- n (15:32) The names listed in verses 21–32 number more than twenty-nine. Some names may be combined (for example, Ain and Rimmon, which are one place, En-rimmon, in Nehemiah 11:29), or some may have been added to the list later.
- o (15:45) Hebrew "daughters," that is, dependent towns; so throughout these lists.
- p (15:59) The Septuagint adds another district of eleven cities here: "Tekoa, Ephrathah (that is, Bethlehem), Peor, Etam, Culon, Tatam, Thobes, Carem, Gallim, Bether, and Manocho: eleven cities with their villages." This district is missing from the Hebrew text, probably through an accidental omission by a copyist whose eye jumped from one "with their villages" to the next.
- q (15:62) Hebrew 'Ir-hammelaḥ.
- r (15:62) En-gedi means "spring of the young goat."

Chapter 16

1 The lot for the descendants of Joseph ran from the Jordan at Jericho,
east of the waters of Jericho, through the wilderness, going up from
Jericho into the hill country of Bethel. 2 Then it went from Bethel to
Luz[a] and passed along to Ataroth, the territory of the Archites. 3 Then

it went down westward to the territory of the Japhletites, as far as the territory of Lower Beth-horon, and to Gezer, and it ended at the sea. 4 The people of Joseph, Manasseh and Ephraim, received their inheritance.

5 The territory of the people of Ephraim[b] according to their clans was this: the border of their inheritance on the east was Ataroth-addar as far as Upper Beth-horon, 6 and the border went out to the sea. On the north was Michmethath. Then on the east the border turned around toward Taanath-shiloh and passed along beyond it on the east to Janoah. 7 Then it went down from Janoah to Ataroth and to Naarah, touched Jericho, and went out to the Jordan. 8 From Tappuah the border ran west to Brook Kanah[c] and ended at the sea. This was the inheritance of the tribe of Ephraim's descendants, by their clans, 9 along with the cities set aside for the Ephraimites within the inheritance of Manasseh's descendants—all those cities and their villages. 10 But they did not drive out the Canaanites living in Gezer, so the Canaanites live among the Ephraimites to this day, serving as forced laborers.[d]

Notes

- a (16:2) Luz means "almond tree." It was the older name of Bethel (Genesis 28:19), but here the two seem to be distinguished.
- b (16:5) Ephraim means "doubly fruitful" (Genesis 41:52).
- c (16:8) Kanah means "reed."
- d (16:10) The Septuagint lacks "and they have become forced laborers." Instead it adds, "until Pharaoh king of Egypt went up and took it and burned it with fire, and the Canaanites and Perizzites and those living in Gaza they destroyed, and Pharaoh gave them as a dowry to his daughter." Compare 1 Kings 9:16.

Chapter 17

1 This was the allotment for the tribe of Manasseh,[a] for he was the firstborn of Joseph. To Machir the firstborn of Manasseh, the father of Gilead, because he was a man of war, were allotted Gilead and Bashan. 2 Portions were also allotted to the rest of Manasseh's descendants, clan by clan: the descendants of Abiezer, of Helek, of Asriel, of Shechem, of Hepher, and of Shemida. These were the male descendants of Manasseh son of Joseph, by their clans.

3 Zelophehad son of Hepher, son of Gilead, son of Machir, son of Manasseh, had no sons, only daughters, whose names were Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah. 4 They approached Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun, and the leaders, saying, "Yahweh commanded Moses to give us an inheritance among our brothers." So, at Yahweh's command, he gave them an inheritance among their father's brothers. 5 So ten portions fell to Manasseh, besides the land of Gilead and Bashan across the Jordan, 6 since Manasseh's daughters received an inheritance along with his sons. The land of Gilead went to the rest of Manasseh's descendants.

7 Manasseh's territory extended from Asher to Michmethath, east of Shechem; then the border ran south toward those living at En-tappuah. 8 The land of Tappuah[b] belonged to Manasseh, but the town of Tappuah on the border of Manasseh belonged to the people of Ephraim. 9 Then the border went down to the brook Kanah. South of the brook, these cities belonged to Ephraim among the cities of Manasseh. The territory of Manasseh lay on the north side of the brook and ended at the sea, 10 The land to the south belonged to Ephraim and to the north to Manasseh, with the sea as its boundary. On the north it touched Asher, and on the east Issachar. 11 In Issachar and Asher, Manasseh also held Beth-shean and its towns, Ibleam and its towns, and the inhabitants of Dor, En-dor, Taanach, and Megiddo with their towns; the third being Naphath.[c] 12 Yet the Manassites were unable to take those cities, because the Canaanites were determined to stay in that land. 13 When the Israelites grew strong, they put the Canaanites to forced labor, but did not utterly drive them out.

14 The descendants of Joseph said to Joshua, "Why have you given me only one lot and one portion as an inheritance, when I am a numerous people whom Yahweh has blessed until now?" 15 Joshua answered them, "If you are so numerous, go up on your own to the forest and clear land for yourselves in the country of the Perizzites and the Rephaim, since the hill country of Ephraim is too small for you." 16 The descendants of Joseph said, "The hill country is not enough for us, and all the Canaanites living in the valley lands, in Beth-shean and its towns and in the Valley of Jezreel,[d] have iron chariots." 17 Then Joshua

spoke to the house of Joseph—Ephraim and Manasseh—saying, “You are a numerous people with great power; you will not have just one lot, 18 for the hill country will be yours. Though it is forested, you will clear it and own it to its farthest limits. You will drive out the Canaanites, even though they have iron chariots and are strong.”

Notes

- a (17:1) Manasseh means “making forget” (Genesis 41:51). Parts of this chapter (verses 1–5 and 11–15) are preserved in the Qumran scroll 4QJosh-b (about 50 B.C.), which agrees closely with the Hebrew text.
- b (17:8) Tappuah means “apple” (or another fruit tree); so also En-tappuah, “apple spring,” in verse 7.
- c (17:11) Or “the three heights.” The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint lacks Ibleam and En-dor here and reads “the third part of Napheth.”
- d (17:16) Jezreel means “God sows.”

Chapter 18

1 The whole congregation of the Israelites gathered at Shiloh[a] and set up the tent of meeting there, with the land under their control.
2 Seven tribes among the Israelites still had not received their inheritance. 3 So Joshua told the Israelites, “How long will you delay entering to take possession of the land that Yahweh, the God of your fathers, has given you? 4 Choose three men from each tribe, and I will send them out to travel through the land. They are to write a description of it according to how they will be inherited, and then return to me. 5 They are to divide it into seven parts. Judah will stay in its territory to the south, and the house of Joseph will stay in its territory to the north. 6 You are to write a description of the land in seven divisions and bring it here to me. I will cast lots for you here before Yahweh our God. 7 For the Levites have no portion among you, for the priesthood of Yahweh is their inheritance. And Gad and Reuben and the half-tribe of Manasseh have received their inheritance beyond the Jordan eastward, which Moses the servant of Yahweh gave them.”
8 The men set out, and Joshua instructed those who went to describe the land in writing: “Go and walk through the land, write a description of it, and come back to me. Here at Shiloh, before Yahweh, I will

cast lots for you." 9 So the men went and traveled through the land,
and they recorded it in a book, city by city, in seven divisions. Then
they returned to Joshua in the camp at Shiloh. 10 Joshua cast lots for
them at Shiloh before Yahweh. There Joshua apportioned the land to
the Israelites according to their divisions.
11 The lot for the tribe of Benjamin's descendants[b] came up, by their
clans, and the territory assigned to them lay between the descendants
of Judah and of Joseph. 12 Their northern boundary started at the
Jordan, climbed to the slope north of Jericho, then went up west
through the hill country and ended at the wilderness of Beth-aven. 13
From there the border crossed south toward Luz, to Luz's slope (that
is, Bethel), and descended to Ataroth-addar, on the hill south of Lower
Beth-horon. 14 Then the boundary turned and curved along the west
side toward the south, from the hill facing Beth-horon on the south,
and finished at Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim), a city of Judah's
descendants. That was the western side. 15 The southern side began at
the outskirts of Kiriath-jearim. The border went out westward[c] and
went to the spring of the waters of Nephtoah. 16 The border descended
to the foot of the mountain facing the Valley of the Son of Hinnom,
at the north end of the Valley of Rephaim, ran down the Hinnom
Valley along the Jebusite's southern slope, and reached En-rogel. 17
Then it bent in a northerly direction, going out to En-shemesh, and
from there to Geliloth, which is opposite the ascent of Adummim.
Then it went down to the stone of Bohan the son of Reuben, 18 passed
on to the north of the shoulder of Beth-arabah,[d] and went down to
the Arabah. 19 The border continued north of the slope of Beth-hoglah
and ended at the Salt Sea's northern inlet, at the Jordan's southern
end. That was the southern boundary. 20 The Jordan bounded it on
the east. This was the inheritance of Benjamin's descendants by their
clans, with its boundaries all around.
21 The cities of the tribe of Benjamin, by their clans, were Jericho, Beth-
hoglah, and Emek-keziz, 22 also Beth-arabah, Zemaraim, and Bethel, 23
also Avvim, Parah, and Ophrah, 24 and Chephar-ammoni, Ophni, and
Geba—twelve cities and their villages. 25 Gibeon, Ramah,[e] Beeroth, 26
Mizpeh, Chephirah, Mozah, 27 Rekem, Irpeel, Taralah, 28 Zela, Haeleph,

the Jebusite city (that is, Jerusalem), Gibeath,[f] and Kiriath[g]—fourteen cities and their villages. This was the inheritance of Benjamin's descendants, by their clans.

Notes

- a (18:1) Shiloh may mean "place of rest" or "tranquility." It became the site of the sanctuary through the period of the judges (1 Samuel 1–4).
- b (18:11) Benjamin means "son of the right hand" or "son of the south" (Genesis 35:18).
- c (18:15) Or "to the west." The text is difficult; the Septuagint reads "to Gasin."
- d (18:18) The Hebrew reads "to the shoulder opposite the Arabah." Some ancient witnesses read "Beth-arabah," as in 15:6.
- e (18:25) Ramah means "height."
- f (18:28) Gibeath means "hill." This is probably Gibeah, Saul's town (1 Samuel 10:26).
- g (18:28) Hebrew Qiryat, "city." Some propose reading Kiriath-jearim, but 18:14 assigns that city to Judah.

Chapter 19

1 The second lot fell to Simeon,[a] to the tribe of Simeon's descendants
by their clans, and their inheritance lay within the inheritance of
Judah's descendants. 2 Their inheritance included Beersheba, Sheba,[b]
and Moladah, 3 also Hazar-shual, Balah, and Ezem, 4 also Eltolad,
Bethul, and Hormah, 5 also Ziklag, Beth-marcaboth, and Hazar-susah,
6 also Beth-lebaoth and Sharuhen—thirteen cities and their villages;
7 Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan: four cities with their villages, 8
as well as all the villages around these cities up to Baalath-beer,
Ramah in the Negev. This was the inheritance of Simeon's tribe, by
their clans. 9 Simeon's inheritance was taken from Judah's territory,
because Judah's portion was too large for them; so the Simeonites
received their inheritance within Judah's.
10 The third lot came up for Zebulun's descendants,[c] by their clans.
Their inherited territory extended to Sarid. 11 Then their border went
up westward and on to Maralah, touched Dabbesheth, then the brook
that is east of Jokneam. 12 From Sarid it went in the other direction
eastward toward the sunrise to the border of Chisloth-tabor. From
there it went to Daberath, then up to Japhia. 13 From there it crossed
eastward, toward the sunrise, to Gath-hepher and Eth-kazin, and

continued to Rimmon, where it curved toward Neah. 14 Then on the
north the border turned about to Hannathon, and it ended at the
Valley of Iphtahel, 15 with Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah, and Beth-
lehem[d]—twelve cities and their villages. 16 That was the inheritance of
Zebulun's descendants by their clans—these cities and their villages.
17 The fourth lot fell to Issachar,[e] to Issachar's descendants by their
clans. 18 Their territory included Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem, 19
Hapharaim, Shion, Anaharath, 20 Rabbith, Kishion, Ebez, 21 Remeth,
En-gannim, En-haddah, and Beth-pazzez. 22 The border also touched
Tabor, Shahazumah, and Beth-shemesh, and their border ended at the
Jordan: sixteen cities with their villages. 23 That was the inheritance
of Issachar's tribe by their clans—the cities and their villages.
24 The fifth lot fell to the tribe of Asher's descendants[f] by their clans.
25 Their territory included Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph, 26 also
Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal. On the west it reached Carmel[g] and
Shihor-libnath. 27 Then it turned east toward Beth-dagon, reached
Zebulun and the Valley of Iphtahel, and went north to Beth-emek
and Neiel, continuing north to Cabul, 28 Ebron,[h] Rehob, Hammon, and
Kanah, as far as Great Sidon. 29 Then the border turned toward Ramah
and the fortified city of Tyre.[i] It then turned to Hosah and ended at the
sea; there were also Mahalab,[j] Achzib, 30 Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob:
twenty-two cities with their villages. 31 That was the inheritance of
Asher's tribe by their clans—these cities and their villages.
32 The sixth lot fell to Naphtali's descendants,[k] by their clans. 33 Their
border ran from Heleph and the oak at Zaanannim, with Adami-
nekeb and Jabneel, to Lakkum, and ended at the Jordan. 34 Then the
border turned westward to Aznoth-tabor and went from there to
Hukkok, touching Zebulun on the south and Asher on the west and
Judah[l] at the Jordan on the east. 35 The fortified cities were Ziddim,
Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Chinnereth, 36 Adamah, Ramah, Hazor, 37
Kedesh, Edrei, En-hazor, 38 Yiron, Migdal-el, Horem, Beth-anath, and
Beth-shemesh: nineteen cities with their villages. 39 That was the
inheritance of Naphtali's tribe by their clans—the cities and their
villages.

40 The seventh lot fell to Dan's tribe[m] by their clans. 41 Their inherited
territory included Zorah, Eshtaol, and Ir-shemesh, 42 also Shaalabbin,
Aijalon, and Ithlah, 43 also Elon, Timnah, and Ekron, 44 also Eltekeh,
Gibbethon, and Baalath, 45 also Jehud, Bene-berak, and Gath-rimmon,
46 and Me-jarkon and Rakkon with the territory over against Joppa.
47 When the territory of the Danites slipped from them,[n] the Danites
went up, fought against Leshem, took it, and put it to the sword; they
occupied it and lived there, and they called Leshem "Dan," after the
name of their ancestor Dan. 48 That was the inheritance of Dan's tribe
by their clans—these cities and their villages.
49 After they had finished distributing the lands as inheritances, the
Israelites gave Joshua son of Nun an inheritance among them. 50
By command of Yahweh they gave him the city that he asked for,
Timnath-serah[o] in the hill country of Ephraim. He rebuilt the city and
settled in it.
51 These are the inheritances that Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of
Nun, and the family heads of the tribes of Israel distributed by lot at
Shiloh, before Yahweh, at the entrance of the tent of meeting. So they
completed the dividing of the land.

Notes

- a (19:1) Simeon means "heard" (Genesis 29:33).
- b (19:2) Or "Shema," as in 15:26 and 1 Chronicles 4:28; the list totals thirteen only if Sheba is a repetition of Beersheba.
- c (19:10) Zebulun may mean "honor" or "dwelling" (Genesis 30:20).
- d (19:15) This is a Bethlehem in Galilee, about 7 miles (11 kilometers) northwest of Nazareth, not Bethlehem of Judah.
- e (19:17) Issachar sounds like the Hebrew for "there is a reward" (Genesis 30:18).
- f (19:24) Asher means "happy" or "blessed" (Genesis 30:13).
- g (19:26) Carmel means "garden land" or "orchard."
- h (19:28) Some Hebrew manuscripts read Abdon (compare 21:30).
- i (19:29) Tyre (Hebrew Tsor) means "rock."
- j (19:29) Hebrew "from Hebel"; the reading Mahalab, a town known from Assyrian records, involves a slight change.
- k (19:32) Naphtali means "my wrestling" (Genesis 30:8).
- l (19:34) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint lacks "and Judah." The phrase may refer to Jair's towns east of the Jordan (1 Chronicles 2:21–23), or the text may be damaged.
- m (19:40) Dan means "he judged" or "judge" (Genesis 30:6).

- n (19:47) Literally “went out from them.” The Septuagint has a different text in verses 47–48. It says that the Amorites pressed the Danites into the hill country and did not let them come down into the valley, that the Danites took Lachish (the Hebrew has Leshem) and called it Lasendan, and that the Amorites stayed in Edom and Shaalbim until Ephraim made them pay tribute. Compare Judges 1:34–35; 18:27–29.
- o (19:50) Timnath-serah means “portion that remains” (or “extra portion”). Judges 2:9 calls it Timnath-heres, “portion of the sun,” and Serah may be a deliberate reversal of the letters. The Septuagint spells it Thamnasarach.

Chapter 20

1 Then Yahweh spoke to Joshua, saying, 2 “Speak to the Israelites, saying, ‘Appoint the cities of refuge, of which I spoke to you through Moses, 3 so that the manslayer who strikes any person unintentionally, without knowing it, may flee there. They are to be for you a refuge from the avenger of blood.[a] 4 He shall flee to one of these cities, stand at the entrance of its gate, and state his case to that city’s elders. They shall then bring him into the city, give him a place, and he shall live among them.[b] 5 If the avenger of blood pursues him, they are not to give up the manslayer into his hand, because he struck his neighbor without knowing it and did not hate him in the past. 6 He must live in that city until the assembly has judged his case, and until the high priest serving at that time has died. Only then may the killer return to the town from which he fled, to his own home.’”

7 So they set apart Kedesh[c] in Galilee[d] in the hill country of Naphtali, Shechem[e] in the hill country of Ephraim, and Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron) in the hill country of Judah. 8 On the east side of the Jordan, opposite Jericho, they set apart Bezer, in the wilderness on the tableland, belonging to Reuben; Ramoth in Gilead, belonging to Gad; and Golan in Bashan, belonging to Manasseh. 9 These were the cities set aside for all the Israelites, and for the foreign resident among them, so that anyone who killed a person accidentally could flee there and not be killed by the avenger of blood before standing trial before the congregation.

Notes

- a (20:3) Hebrew go'el haddam, the nearest relative, whose duty was to take responsibility for a family member's death. The same word go'el means "redeemer" elsewhere (Ruth 4:1–6).
- b (20:4) The Septuagint lacks verses 4–6 and the phrase "without knowing it" in verse 3. In verse 3 it reads instead, "until he stands before the congregation for judgment." The longer Hebrew text echoes Deuteronomy 19:1–13, while the shorter Greek text echoes Numbers 35:9–28.
- c (20:7) Kedesh means "holy place."
- d (20:7) Galilee (Hebrew Galil) means "circle" or "district."
- e (20:7) Shechem means "shoulder" or "ridge," perhaps from its position on the saddle between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim.

Chapter 21

1 Then the heads of the fathers' houses of the Levites came to Eleazar
the priest and to Joshua the son of Nun and to the heads of the
fathers' houses of the tribes of the Israelites. 2 At Shiloh in the land
of Canaan they told them, "Yahweh commanded through Moses that
we be given towns to live in, with pastureland for our livestock." 3 So
by command of Yahweh the Israelites gave to the Levites from their
inheritance these cities and their pasturelands.
4 The first lot fell to the Kohathite clans. The Levites who were de-
scendants of Aaron the priest received thirteen cities by lot from the
tribes of Judah, Simeon, and Benjamin. 5 The remaining Kohathites
received ten cities by lot from the clans of Ephraim, from Dan, and
from half of Manasseh. 6 The Gershonites received thirteen cities by
lot from the clans of Issachar, Asher, Naphtali, and the half-tribe of
Manasseh in Bashan. 7 The Merarites, by their clans, received twelve
cities from Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun. 8 The Israelites gave these cities
with their pastures to the Levites by lot, as Yahweh had commanded
through Moses.
9 From the tribes of Judah and Simeon they gave these cities, listed by
name, 10 which went to Aaron's descendants, of the Kohathite clans
of Levi's descendants, since the first lot was theirs. 11 They gave them
Kiriath-arba (Arba was the father of Anak), that is, Hebron, in the
hill country of Judah, with the pasturelands around it. 12 The fields
around the city and its villages, however, were given to Caleb son of
Jephunneh as his own.

13 To Aaron the priest's descendants they gave Hebron, a city of refuge
for the killer, with its pastures, along with Libnah and its pastures, 14
Jattir with its pasturelands, Eshtemoa with its pasturelands, 15 Holon
with its pasturelands, Debir with its pasturelands, 16 Ain,[a] Juttah, and
Beth-shemesh, each with its pastures—nine cities from these two
tribes. 17 Then out of the tribe of Benjamin: Gibeon with its pasture-
lands, Geba with its pasturelands, 18 Anathoth[b] with its pasturelands,
and Almon with its pasturelands: four cities. 19 Altogether the cities
of Aaron's descendants, the priests, were thirteen cities with their
pastures.
20 As for the remaining Kohathite clans of the Levites, their allotted
cities came from the tribe of Ephraim. 21 They were given Shechem,
a city of refuge for the killer, with its pastures in the hill country of
Ephraim, and Gezer with its pastures, 22 Kibzaim with its pasturelands,
Beth-horon with its pasturelands: four cities. 23 From the tribe of
Dan: Elteke and Gibbethon, each with its pastures, 24 Aijalon with its
pasturelands, Gath-rimmon with its pasturelands: four cities. 25 From
the half-tribe of Manasseh: Taanach and Gath-rimmon,[c] each with its
pastures—two cities. 26 In all, the cities for the clans of the remaining
Kohathites were ten, with their pastures.
27 To the Gershonites, a Levite clan, they gave from the half-tribe of
Manasseh: Golan in Bashan, a city of refuge for the killer, and Be-
eshterah,[d] each with its pastures—two cities. 28 From the tribe of
Issachar: Kishion and Daberath, each with its pastures, 29 Jarmuth
with its pasturelands, En-gannim with its pasturelands: four cities. 30
From the tribe of Asher: Mishal and Abdon, each with its pastures, 31
Helkath with its pasturelands, and Rehob with its pasturelands: four
cities. 32 From the tribe of Naphtali: Kedesh in Galilee, a city of refuge
for the killer, Hammoth-dor, and Kartan, each with its pastures—three
cities. 33 Altogether the cities of the Gershonite clans were thirteen,
with their pastures.
34 To the rest of the Levites, the Merarite clans, they gave from the tribe
of Zebulun: Jokneam and Kartah, each with its pastures, 35 Dimnah
with its pasturelands, Nahalal with its pasturelands: four cities. 36
From the tribe of Reuben:[e] Bezer and Jahaz, each with its pastures, 37

Kedemoth with its pasturelands, and Mephaath with its pasturelands:
four cities. 38 From the tribe of Gad: Ramoth in Gilead, a city of refuge
for the killer, and Mahanaim, each with its pastures, 39 Heshbon and
Jazer, each with its pastures—four cities in all. 40 All the cities allotted
to the Merarite clans, the rest of the Levite families, came to twelve.
41 The cities of the Levites in the midst of the possession of the
Israelites were in all forty-eight cities with their pasturelands. 42 Each
of these cities had pastureland surrounding it; this was true of all
of them.[f]
43 So Yahweh gave Israel all the land he had sworn to give their fathers,
and they took possession of it and settled in it. 44 Yahweh gave them
rest on every side just as he had sworn to their fathers. Not one of
all their enemies had withstood them, for Yahweh had given all their
enemies into their hands. 45 Of all the good promises Yahweh had
made to the house of Israel, not one word failed; every one came true.

Notes

- a (21:16) Ain means "spring." The Septuagint and 1 Chronicles 6:59 read Ashan.
- b (21:18) Anathoth was later the hometown of the prophet Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:1).
- c (21:25) The repetition of Gath-rimmon from verse 24 is probably a copying error. 1 Chronicles 6:70 has Bileam (that is, Ibleam), and the Septuagint reads Iebatha.
- d (21:27) Be-eshterah is probably a contraction of Beth-ashtarah, "house of Astarte." 1 Chronicles 6:71 has Ashtaroth.
- e (21:36) Verses 36–37 are lacking in many Hebrew manuscripts and in some printed editions of the Hebrew Bible, though the edition followed here includes them. They are present in the Septuagint and in 1 Chronicles 6:78–79, and the totals in verses 7 and 40 (twelve cities) require them.
- f (21:42) The Septuagint adds, "And Joshua finished dividing the land by its borders. And the Israelites gave a portion to Joshua by the command of the Lord. They gave him the city that he asked for, Thamnasachar in the hill country of Ephraim. And Joshua built the city and lived in it. And Joshua took the flint knives with which he had circumcised the Israelites who were born in the wilderness on the way, and put them in Thamnasachar." Compare 19:49–50 and 24:31 (Septuagint).

Chapter 22

1 Then Joshua summoned the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-
tribe of Manasseh 2 and said to them, "You have kept all that Moses
the servant of Yahweh commanded you, and you have obeyed my
voice in all that I have commanded you. 3 All these many days, up to

this day, you have not abandoned your brothers, but have kept the charge Yahweh your God gave you. 4 And now Yahweh your God has given rest to your brothers, as he promised them. Therefore turn now and go to your tents, to the land of your possession, which Moses the servant of Yahweh gave you beyond the Jordan. 5 Only be very careful to observe the commandment and the law that Moses the servant of Yahweh commanded you, to love Yahweh your God, to walk in all his ways, to keep his commandments, to hold fast to him, and to serve him with all your heart and with all your soul." 6 So Joshua blessed them and sent them away, and they went to their tents.

7 To one half of the tribe of Manasseh Moses had given land in Bashan, while to the other half Joshua gave land alongside their brothers west of the Jordan. When Joshua sent them home to their tents and blessed them, 8 he said to them, "Go back to your tents with great wealth and with very much livestock, with silver, gold, bronze, and iron, and with very many garments. Divide the spoil of your enemies with your brothers."

9 So the Reubenites, Gadites, and half-tribe of Manasseh left the Israelites at Shiloh in the land of Canaan and went back to Gilead, the land they owned, which they had taken by Yahweh's command through Moses.

10 When they reached the district[a] of the Jordan in the land of Canaan, the Reubenites, Gadites, and half-tribe of Manasseh built an altar there beside the Jordan, an altar that was impressive in size. 11 The Israelites were told, "The Reubenites, Gadites, and half-tribe of Manasseh have built an altar at the border of Canaan, in the Jordan district, on the side that faces the Israelites." 12 When the Israelites heard this, the whole congregation of Israel assembled at Shiloh to go to war against them.

13 Then the Israelites sent to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, in the land of Gilead, Phinehas[b] the son of Eleazar the priest, 14 and with him ten chiefs, one from each of the fathers' houses of each of the tribes of Israel, every one of them the head of a fathers' house among the clans[c] of Israel. 15 They came to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, in the

land of Gilead, and they said to them, 16 "This is the word of the whole congregation of Yahweh: 'What is this unfaithfulness you have shown toward the God of Israel, turning away today from following Yahweh by building yourselves an altar and rebelling against Yahweh today? 17 Was the iniquity of Peor[d] too little for us, from which we are not yet cleansed to this day, though a plague struck the congregation of Yahweh, 18 that you too must turn away this day from following Yahweh? If you too rebel against Yahweh today, then tomorrow he will be angry with the whole congregation of Israel. 19 Yet if you find the land you hold to be unclean, then cross to Yahweh's own land, where his tabernacle stands, and settle among us. But never rebel against Yahweh, nor make us rebels, by raising an altar for yourselves apart from the altar of Yahweh our God. 20 Did not Achan son of Zerah act unfaithfully regarding what was set apart for destruction, so that wrath fell on the whole congregation of Israel? He was not the only one to die for his iniquity.'"

21 The Reubenites, Gadites, and half-tribe of Manasseh answered the heads of the families of Israel: 22 "The Mighty One, God, Yahweh! The Mighty One, God, Yahweh![e] He knows, and Israel too shall know! If this was rebellion or unfaithfulness toward Yahweh, do not save us today 23 by building an altar to turn away from Yahweh. And if our purpose was to offer on it burnt offerings, grain offerings, or peace offerings, may Yahweh himself require an account. 24 No! We acted from a worry that in days to come your children would say to our children, 'What business do you have with Yahweh, the God of Israel? 25 For Yahweh has made the Jordan a boundary between us and you, you Reubenites and Gadites. You have no portion in Yahweh.' So your children might make our children cease to fear Yahweh. 26 That is why we said, 'Let us get ready to build an altar—not for burnt offering and not for sacrifice, 27 but to be a witness between you and us, and between our generations after us, that we do serve Yahweh before him with our burnt offerings, our sacrifices, and our peace offerings; then your children will not be able to tell our children in days to come, "You have no share in Yahweh."' 28 And we thought, 'If they ever say this to us or to our descendants in the future, we will reply, "See

the likeness of Yahweh's altar, which our fathers built, not for burnt offerings or sacrifices, but as a witness between you and us."' [29] Far be it from us that we should rebel against Yahweh and turn away this day from following Yahweh by building an altar for burnt offering, grain offering, or sacrifice, other than the altar of Yahweh our God that stands before his tabernacle!"
[30] When Phinehas the priest, with the leaders of the congregation, the heads of Israel's families who were with him, heard the words spoken by the Reubenites, Gadites, and Manassites, it pleased them. [31] Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest told the Reubenites, Gadites, and Manassites, "Today we know that Yahweh is among us, since you have not committed this act of unfaithfulness against Yahweh. You have now rescued the Israelites from Yahweh's hand."
[32] Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest and the leaders then turned back from the Reubenites and Gadites in Gilead and returned to Canaan, to the Israelites, and gave them the report. [33] The report pleased the Israelites, and they blessed God. They said no more about going to war to destroy the land in which the Reubenites and Gadites lived. [34] The Reubenites and Gadites named the altar Witness,[f] saying, "It is a witness between us that Yahweh is God."

Notes

- a (22:10) Hebrew gelilot, "circles" or "districts," possibly a place name, Geliloth; so in verse 11. The Septuagint reads "Galaad" (Gilead).
- b (22:13) Phinehas is an Egyptian name, probably meaning "the Nubian" (Numbers 25:7).
- c (22:14) Hebrew "thousands," a term for clan divisions; so in verses 21 and 30.
- d (22:17) See Numbers 25:1–9.
- e (22:22) Hebrew El Elohim Yahweh, three names for God, repeated as a solemn oath.
- f (22:34) Hebrew 'ed, "witness." The name is not in the standard Hebrew text, which reads "called the altar, 'For it is a witness…'" Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Syriac supply it. The Septuagint reads, "Joshua gave a name to the altar… and said, 'It is a witness in the midst of them.'"

Chapter 23

[1] Long afterward, when Yahweh had given Israel rest from all their enemies around them, and Joshua had grown old and was well along

in years, 2 Joshua called together all Israel—its elders, heads, judges,
and officers—and told them, "I am old and well along in years. 3 You
have seen all that Yahweh your God has done to all these nations for
your sake, for it is Yahweh your God who has fought for you. 4 Look,
I have assigned to you, as an inheritance for your tribes, the nations
that remain, as well as all the nations I have cut off, from the Jordan
to the Great Sea on the west. 5 Yahweh your God himself will thrust
them out from before you and drive them away from you, and you
will take possession of their land, as Yahweh your God promised you.
6 So be very strong to keep and do everything written in the book
of the law of Moses, without turning from it to the right or to the
left, 7 so that you do not mingle with these nations left among you,
mention the names of their gods, swear by them, serve them, or bow
down to them, 8 but you are to cling to Yahweh your God just as you
have done to this day. 9 For Yahweh has driven out great and mighty
nations ahead of you; as for you, up to this day no one has withstood
you. 10 A single one of you chases a thousand, because Yahweh your
God is the one fighting for you, as he promised you. 11 Be very careful,
therefore, for your own sakes, to love Yahweh your God. 12 For if you
turn away and hold fast to the survivors of these nations that remain
among you, and intermarry with them and mix with them and they
with you, 13 know for certain that Yahweh your God will not go on
driving these nations out ahead of you. They will become snares and
traps for you, whips on your sides and thorns in your eyes, until you
perish from this good land Yahweh your God has given you.
14 "I am now about to go the way of all the earth. All of you know
in your hearts and souls that not one of all the good things Yahweh
your God spoke concerning you has failed. Everything has come true
for you; not one of them has failed. 15 But just as every good thing
Yahweh your God promised you has come to you, so Yahweh will
bring on you every evil thing until he has wiped you out from this
good land that Yahweh your God has given you, 16 if you break the
covenant of Yahweh your God that he commanded you, and go serve
other gods and bow down to them. Then Yahweh's anger will burn

against you, and you will quickly perish from the good land he has given you."[a]

Notes

- a (23:16) The Septuagint lacks the last sentence of this verse ("Then the anger of Yahweh…").

Chapter 24

1 Joshua assembled all the tribes of Israel at Shechem[a] and called for
the elders, heads, judges, and officers of Israel, and they stood before
God. 2 Joshua told all the people, "Here is what Yahweh, Israel's God,
declares: 'In ancient times your fathers lived on the other side of the
River,[b] namely Terah, the father of Abraham and the father of Nahor,
and they served other gods. 3 But I took your father Abraham from
beyond the River, led him through the whole land of Canaan, and
multiplied his offspring. I gave him Isaac. 4 To Isaac I gave Jacob and
Esau; to Esau I gave Mount Seir's hill country as a possession, while
Jacob and his sons went down to Egypt. 5 Then I sent Moses and
Aaron, and I struck Egypt with what I did in its midst, and afterward
I brought you out.[c] 6 I brought your fathers out of Egypt, and you
came to the sea. The Egyptians pursued your fathers with chariots
and horsemen to the Red Sea. 7 When they cried out to Yahweh, he put
darkness between you and the Egyptians, and brought the sea down
over them and covered them. Your eyes witnessed what I did to the
Egyptians. Afterward you stayed for many days in the wilderness.
8 I brought you into the land of the Amorites who lived east of the
Jordan; they fought against you, but I handed them over to you, and
you took their land, and I destroyed them ahead of you. 9 Then Balak
the son of Zippor, king of Moab, arose and fought against Israel. He
sent and called Balaam the son of Beor to curse you, 10 but I refused to
listen to Balaam, so he actually blessed you, and I rescued you from
his hand. 11 You went over the Jordan and reached Jericho; Jericho's
leaders[d] fought you, and so did the Amorites, Perizzites, Canaanites,
Hittites, Girgashites, Hivites, and Jebusites, but I delivered them into
your hand. 12 I sent the hornet[e] ahead of you, and it drove out the two
kings of the Amorites[f] before you—not by your sword or your bow. 13

I gave you a land you had not tilled and cities you had not built; you
now live in them and eat from vineyards and olive orchards that you
never planted.'
14 "So now fear Yahweh and serve him with integrity and faithfulness.
Throw away the gods your fathers served beyond the River and in
Egypt, and serve Yahweh. 15 But if serving Yahweh seems wrong to
you, choose today whom you will serve: the gods your fathers served
beyond the River, or the gods of the Amorites in whose land you are
living. As for me and my household, we will serve Yahweh."
16 Then the people answered, "Far be it from us that we should forsake
Yahweh to serve other gods, 17 For it is Yahweh our God who brought
up both us and our fathers out of the land of Egypt, from the house
of slavery, who performed those great signs before our eyes and kept
us safe throughout the journey we made and among every nation we
passed through. 18 Yahweh also drove all the peoples out ahead of us,
namely the Amorites who lived in this land. We too, therefore, will
serve Yahweh, for he is our God."
19 But Joshua said to the people, "You are not able to serve Yahweh,
for he is a holy God. He is a jealous God. He will not forgive your
transgressions or your sins. 20 If you forsake Yahweh and serve foreign
gods, then he will turn and do you harm and consume you, after
having done you good." 21 The people said to Joshua, "No, but we will
serve Yahweh." 22 Then Joshua said to the people, "You are witnesses
against yourselves that you have chosen Yahweh, to serve him." And
they said, "We are witnesses." 23 He said, "Then put away the foreign
gods that are among you, and incline your heart to Yahweh, the God
of Israel." 24 The people answered Joshua, "We will serve Yahweh our
God and obey his voice." 25 That day Joshua made a covenant with the
people, and at Shechem[g] he set statutes and ordinances before them.
26 Joshua wrote these words in the Book of the Law of God. And he
took a large stone and set it up there under the oak[h] that was by the
sanctuary of Yahweh. 27 Joshua told all the people, "Look, this stone
will witness against us, for it has heard all the words Yahweh spoke
to us; it will witness against you if you are false to your God." 28 So
Joshua sent the people away, every man to his inheritance.

29 After these things Joshua the son of Nun, the servant of Yahweh,
died, being 110 years old.[i] 30 They buried him within his own inher-
itance at Timnath-serah in the hill country of Ephraim, north of
Mount Gaash.[j] 31 Israel served Yahweh all the days of Joshua, and all
the days of the elders who outlived Joshua and had known all the
work that Yahweh did for Israel.[k]
32 Joseph's bones, which the Israelites had carried up from Egypt, were
buried at Shechem in the parcel of land that Jacob had purchased
from the sons of Hamor, the father of Shechem, for a hundred pieces
of money;[l] it became an inheritance for Joseph's descendants.
33 Eleazar son of Aaron also died, and he was buried at Gibeah,[m] the
property of his son Phinehas, who had been granted it in Ephraim's
hill country.[n]

Notes

- a (24:1) The Septuagint reads Shiloh here and in verse 25. Shechem was the site of Abraham's first altar in the land (Genesis 12:6–7) and of Jacob's burial of foreign gods (Genesis 35:4).
- b (24:2) That is, the Euphrates; so in verses 3, 14, and 15.
- c (24:5) The Septuagint has a shorter text in verses 5–7. It lacks "I sent Moses and Aaron" and some other phrases.
- d (24:11) Hebrew ba'ale, "the lords" or "citizens."
- e (24:12) Or "panic" or "terror" (Hebrew tsir'ah). Compare Exodus 23:28 and Deuteronomy 7:20.
- f (24:12) The Septuagint reads "twelve kings of the Amorites." The Hebrew "two kings" refers to Sihon and Og (2:10).
- g (24:25) The Septuagint reads "at Shiloh, before the tabernacle of the God of Israel."
- h (24:26) Or "terebinth," a large tree. Compare Genesis 35:4, where Jacob hid foreign gods under the oak near Shechem.
- i (24:29) An age of 110 years was considered the ideal life span in Egypt. Joseph died at the same age (Genesis 50:26).
- j (24:30) Gaash may mean "quaking" or "shaking."
- k (24:31) The Septuagint places this verse before Joshua's death (as verse 29). After the burial account it adds that Joshua's flint blades, used to circumcise the Israelites at Gilgal once he had led them out of Egypt, were laid beside him in his grave, just as the Lord had commanded, and that they remain there to this day. Compare the Septuagint addition at 21:42.
- l (24:32) Hebrew "for a hundred qesitah," a unit of uncertain value, perhaps a weight of silver; it appears elsewhere only in Genesis 33:19 and Job 42:11. The Septuagint reads "for a hundred ewe-lambs." Compare Genesis 33:19; Acts 7:16.

- m (24:33) Gibeah means “hill.” The Septuagint reads Gabaar.
- n (24:33) The Septuagint adds a longer ending: “On that day the Israelites took the ark of God and carried it around among them. And Phinehas served as priest in place of Eleazar his father until he died, and he was buried in his own place, Gabaar. And the Israelites went away, each to his own place and to his own city. And the Israelites worshiped Astarte and Ashtaroth and the gods of the nations around them. And the Lord gave them into the hands of Eglon king of Moab, and he ruled over them eighteen years.” This addition links the book to Judges 2:6–13 and 3:12–14.

Judges

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 After the death of Joshua,[a] the Israelites asked Yahweh, "Who will
go up first for us against the Canaanites, to fight against them?" 2
Yahweh said, "Judah will go up. Look, I have given the land into his
hand." 3 Then Judah said to Simeon his brother, "Come up with me into
my allotted territory, and let us fight against the Canaanites. Then I
also will go with you into your allotted territory." So Simeon went
with him. 4 Judah marched out, and Yahweh delivered the Canaanites
and Perizzites to them. At Bezek they killed ten thousand men. 5
At Bezek they located Adoni-bezek[b] and fought him; the Canaanites
and Perizzites were routed. 6 Adoni-bezek fled, but they pursued him,
caught him, and cut off his thumbs and his big toes. 7 Adoni-bezek
confessed, "Seventy kings, each missing his thumbs and big toes,
scavenged leftovers beneath my table. God has paid me back exactly
what I did to them." They led him to Jerusalem, and he died in that
city.
8 The men of Judah fought against Jerusalem and captured it. They
struck it with the edge of the sword and set the city on fire. 9 After-
ward the men of Judah went down to fight against the Canaanites
who lived in the hill country, in the Negev,[c] and in the lowland. 10
Judah then advanced on the Canaanite inhabitants of Hebron (its
older name was Kiriath-arba[d]), and struck down Sheshai, Ahiman,
and Talmai.
11 From there they went against the inhabitants of Debir. (The name
of Debir was formerly Kiriath-sepher.[e]) 12 Caleb declared, "Whoever
assaults and takes Kiriath-sepher, I will give him my daughter Achsah
as a bride." 13 Othniel[f] son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother, took the
town, and Caleb gave him his daughter Achsah as a wife. 14 On her
wedding day she persuaded Othniel to request a field from her father.

She dismounted from her donkey, and Caleb asked, "What would you like?" 15 "Grant me one more favor," she told him. "You have placed me in the dry southland, the Negev, so give me springs as well." Caleb then gave her the upper pools and the lower pools.[g]

16 The Kenite's descendants,[h] kin of Moses' father-in-law, left the City of Palms[i] and went with Judah's people to the Judean desert in the Negev near Arad, where they settled among the people. 17 Judah marched with his brother tribe Simeon, and together they defeated the Canaanites of Zephath and put the town under the ban.[j] The town was renamed Hormah. 18 Judah also captured Gaza with its territory, Ashkelon with its territory, and Ekron with its territory.[k] 19 Yahweh was on Judah's side, and Judah occupied the hill country. But they failed to expel the people living on the coastal plain, since those people owned iron-clad chariots.[l] 20 They gave Hebron to Caleb, as Moses had said, and he drove out from there the three sons of Anak. 21 But the Benjaminites did not drive out the Jebusites who lived in Jerusalem, so the Jebusites have lived with the Benjaminites in Jerusalem to this day.

22 The house of Joseph also went up against Bethel, and Yahweh was with them. 23 The house of Joseph sent spies to Bethel. (The name of the city was formerly Luz.) 24 The scouts saw a man leaving the town and told him, "Tell us the way in, and we will treat you mercifully." 25 He showed them the way into the city, and they struck the city with the edge of the sword, but they let the man and all his family go. 26 The man went to Hittite country, built a town there, and called it Luz, the name it still bears today.

27 Manasseh did not dispossess the residents of Beth-shean with its dependent villages,[m] or of Taanach with its villages, or of Dor, Ibleam, or Megiddo and their villages, because the Canaanites stubbornly held on to that territory. 28 When Israel grew strong, they put the Canaanites to forced labor, but they did not drive them out completely.

29 Ephraim did not drive out the Canaanites who lived in Gezer, so the Canaanites lived among them in Gezer.

30 Zebulun failed to evict the people of Kitron and Nahalol, so the Canaanites lived among them as forced laborers.
31 Asher failed to dispossess the residents of Acco, Sidon, Ahlab, Achzib, Helbah, Aphik, and Rehob. 32 So the Asherites lived among the Canaanites, the inhabitants of the land, for they did not drive them out.
33 Naphtali failed to evict the inhabitants of Beth-shemesh and of Beth-anath, so Naphtali settled among the Canaanites already native to the land. Even so, those two towns' people were reduced to servitude as forced laborers for Naphtali.
34 The Amorites forced the tribe of Dan up into the hills and refused to let them descend onto the lowland. 35 The Amorites held firmly to Har-heres,[n] Aijalon, and Shaalbim, but the tribe of Joseph overpowered them and made them forced laborers. 36 The border of the Amorites[o] ran from the Ascent of Akrabbim,[p] from Sela and upward.

Notes

- a (1:1) The Septuagint of Judges survives in two main Greek forms, the B text (Codex Vaticanus and related manuscripts) and the A text (Codex Alexandrinus and related manuscripts). They differ often in wording and sometimes in sense; significant differences are noted. Joshua means "Yahweh is salvation."
- b (1:5) Adoni-bezek means "lord of Bezek."
- c (1:9) The Negev is the dry southern region of Judah; the word also means "south."
- d (1:10) Kiriath-arba means "city of Arba" or "city of four." Hebron perhaps means "alliance."
- e (1:11) Kiriath-sepher means "town of the book" or "town of the scribe."
- f (1:13) Othniel perhaps means "my strength is God" or "lion of God"; the meaning is uncertain.
- g (1:15) Or "Gulloth-illith and Gulloth-tahtith"; gulloth means "basins" or "pools." Compare Joshua 15:16–19.
- h (1:16) The Septuagint (B text, as in Brenton) names him: "the sons of Jothor (Jethro) the Kenite." Compare 4:11, which calls Moses' father-in-law Hobab.
- i (1:16) That is, Jericho (Deuteronomy 34:3).
- j (1:17) Hebrew charam, to give over completely to God, usually by destruction. Hormah sounds like the word for "devoted to destruction."
- k (1:18) The Septuagint reads the opposite: "But Judah did not take possession of Gaza and its territory, nor Ashkelon and its territory, nor Ekron and its territory, nor Ashdod and the land around it." This agrees with verse 19 and with the later history of the Philistine cities.

- l (1:19) Hebrew rekeb barzel. The Septuagint (B text) takes rekeb as a name: "because Rechab prevented them."
- m (1:27) Hebrew "daughters," the usual term for the smaller towns dependent on a city; so throughout this verse.
- n (1:35) Har-heres means "mountain of the sun." Compare Ir-shemesh ("city of the sun") in Joshua 19:41.
- o (1:36) Some Septuagint manuscripts and many scholars read "Edomites," which fits the location of the Ascent of Akrabbim.
- p (1:36) Akrabbim means "scorpions." Sela means "rock."

Chapter 2

1 Yahweh's messenger came from Gilgal up to Bochim.[a] He announced, "I led you out of Egypt and into the country I promised your ancestors. I told you, 'I will never annul my covenant with you, 2 and you must make no covenant with the inhabitants of this land; you must tear down their altars.' But you have not obeyed my voice. What is this you have done? 3 So now I say, I will not drive them out before you, but they will become thorns in your sides,[b] and their gods will be a snare to you." 4 When Yahweh's messenger finished speaking to all Israel, the people broke into loud weeping. 5 So they called the name of that place Bochim, and they sacrificed there to Yahweh.

6 Joshua dismissed the people, and the Israelites each went to occupy their own allotted land. 7 The people served Yahweh all the days of Joshua and all the days of the elders who outlived Joshua, who had seen all the great work that Yahweh had done for Israel. 8 Joshua son of Nun, the servant of Yahweh, died at the age of a hundred and ten years. 9 They buried him within the boundary of his inheritance at Timnath-heres,[c] in the hill country of Ephraim, north of Mount Gaash. 10 And all that generation also were gathered to their fathers. Another generation arose after them who did not know Yahweh or the work that he had done for Israel.

11 The Israelites did evil in Yahweh's sight, worshiping the Baals.[d] 12 They abandoned Yahweh, the God their ancestors had worshiped, who had rescued them from Egypt. They followed other gods, those of the neighboring peoples, bowing before them and making Yahweh furious. 13 They abandoned Yahweh and served Baal and the Ashtaroth.[e] 14 Yahweh's fury blazed against Israel, so he surrendered

them to raiders who looted them. He turned them over to the enemies surrounding them, and they lost all power to resist. 15 Whenever they went out, the hand of Yahweh was against them for harm, as Yahweh had said and as Yahweh had sworn to them. And they were in great distress.

16 Then Yahweh raised up judges,[f] who saved them from the hand of those who plundered them. 17 Still, they would not even heed their judges. They chased after other gods like a prostitute, and bowed to them. They swerved quickly from the road their ancestors had followed, which was obedience to Yahweh's commands. They did not follow it. 18 Whenever Yahweh appointed a judge for them, he stood with that judge and rescued them from their enemies throughout the judge's lifetime. Yahweh took pity on them as they groaned under their oppressors and tormentors. 19 But whenever the judge died, they turned back and acted more corruptly than their fathers, going after other gods to serve them and to bow down to them. They did not give up any of their practices or their stubborn ways.

20 So the anger of Yahweh burned against Israel, and he said, "Because this nation has broken my covenant that I commanded their fathers and has not obeyed my voice, 21 I in turn will no longer drive out before them any of the nations that Joshua left when he died, 22 in order to put Israel to the test through them, to see whether they would follow Yahweh's path as their ancestors did, or not." 23 This is why Yahweh let those nations remain; he did not hurry to dislodge them, and he never handed them over to Joshua.

Notes

- a (2:1) Bochim means "weepers" (verse 5). The Septuagint adds "and to Bethel and to the house of Israel."
- b (2:3) Hebrew "they will be sides to you." "Thorns in" is supplied from the similar warnings in Numbers 33:55 and Joshua 23:13. The Septuagint reads "they will be distresses to you," and the Latin Vulgate "enemies."
- c (2:9) Timnath-heres means "portion of the sun." In Joshua 19:50 and 24:30 the name is Timnath-serah ("remaining portion"), with two letters reversed.
- d (2:11) Baal means "lord" or "master," the title of the Canaanite storm god. The plural refers to the local forms of his worship.

- e (2:13) Ashtaroth is the plural of Ashtoreth (Astarte), a Canaanite goddess of fertility and war.
- f (2:16) Hebrew shophetim, leaders who delivered Israel and governed it, not only judges in a court of law.

Chapter 3

1 Now these are the nations that Yahweh left in order to test Israel by
them, all who had not known any of the wars of Canaan. 2 It was only
so that the generations of the Israelites might know war, to teach it
to those who had not known it before: 3 These were the five Philistine
lords,[a] every Canaanite, the Sidonians, and the Hivites who made
their home in the Lebanon highlands, stretching from Baal-hermon's
mountain to the approach to Hamath.[b] 4 They were left to test Israel by
them, to know whether they would obey the commands of Yahweh,
which he commanded their fathers by the hand of Moses. 5 So the
Israelites lived among the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Amorites, the
Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites. 6 They took their daughters
as wives for themselves and gave their own daughters to their sons,
and they served their gods.
7 The Israelites did what was evil in the eyes of Yahweh. They
forgot Yahweh their God and served the Baals and the Asheroth.[c] 8
So the anger of Yahweh burned against Israel, and he sold them into
the hand of Cushan-rishathaim[d] king of Aram-naharaim,[e] and the
Israelites served Cushan-rishathaim eight years. 9 When the Israelites
cried out to Yahweh, Yahweh raised up a savior for the Israelites, who
saved them: Othniel son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother. 10 The
Spirit of Yahweh came upon him, and he judged Israel. He went out
to war, and Yahweh gave Cushan-rishathaim king of Aram into his
hand, and his hand prevailed over Cushan-rishathaim. 11 So the land
had rest forty years. Then Othniel son of Kenaz died.
12 Again the Israelites did what was evil in the eyes of Yahweh, and
Yahweh strengthened Eglon[f] king of Moab against Israel, because
they had done what was evil in the eyes of Yahweh. 13 He gathered to
himself the Ammonites and the Amalekites, and he went and struck
Israel, and they took possession of the City of Palms. 14 And the
Israelites served Eglon king of Moab eighteen years.

15 Then the Israelites cried out to Yahweh, and Yahweh raised up a
savior for them, Ehud[g] son of Gera, the Benjaminite, a man who was
left-handed.[h] The Israelites sent tribute by him to Eglon king of Moab.
16 Ehud made himself a sword with two edges, about a foot[i] long, and
he strapped it under his clothes on his right thigh. 17 He presented
the tribute to Eglon king of Moab. Now Eglon was a very fat man.
18 When Ehud had finished presenting the tribute, he sent away the
people who had carried the tribute. 19 But he himself turned back at
the carved images[j] near Gilgal and said, "I have a secret message for
you, O king." The king said, "Silence!" And all who stood by him went
out from him. 20 Ehud came to him as he was sitting alone in his cool
upper room. Ehud said, "I have a message from God for you." And he
rose from his seat. 21 Ehud reached with his left hand, took the sword
from his right thigh, and thrust it into his belly. 22 The handle also
went in after the blade, and the fat closed over the blade, for he did
not pull the sword out of his belly. And the dung came out.[k] 23 Then
Ehud went out to the porch[l] and shut the doors of the upper room
behind him and locked them. 24 When he had gone out, the king's
servants came, and they saw that the doors of the upper room were
locked. They said, "Surely he is relieving himself[m] in the inner room
of the cool chamber." 25 They waited so long that they were ashamed,
but he still would not unlock the upstairs room. Finally they fetched
the key and unlocked it, and there lay their master, sprawled dead on
the floor.
26 Ehud escaped while they delayed. He passed beyond the carved
images and escaped to Seirah. 27 When he arrived, he sounded the
ram's horn in the hill country of Ephraim, and the Israelites went
down with him from the hill country, with him at their head. 28 He
said to them, "Follow me, for Yahweh has given your enemies, Moab,
into your hand." So they went down after him and seized the fords of
the Jordan against Moab, and they did not allow anyone to cross. 29
At that time they struck down about ten thousand men of Moab, all
strong, all able men; not one escaped. 30 So Moab was subdued that
day under the hand of Israel, and the land had rest eighty years.

31 Next came Shamgar, Anath's son,[n] who killed six hundred Philistines using a cattle prod. He, too, rescued Israel.

Notes

- a (3:3) Hebrew seren, a Philistine title, perhaps related to the Greek word tyrannos.
- b (3:3) Or "the entrance of Hamath."
- c (3:7) The Asheroth were wooden poles or images associated with the goddess Asherah. The Septuagint reads "the groves."
- d (3:8) Cushan-rishathaim means "Cushan of double wickedness," probably a mocking form of a foreign name.
- e (3:8) That is, "Aram of the two rivers," upper Mesopotamia.
- f (3:12) Eglon sounds like the Hebrew word for "calf" (egel).
- g (3:15) Ehud perhaps means "where is the glory?"; the meaning is uncertain.
- h (3:15) Hebrew "restricted in his right hand." The same expression is used of the Benjaminite slingers in 20:16. Benjamin means "son of the right hand."
- i (3:16) Hebrew gomed, a measure found only here, perhaps a short cubit of about 13 inches (33 cm). The Septuagint reads "a span" (about 9 inches, 23 cm).
- j (3:19) Or "the stone quarries" (also in verse 26). Hebrew pesilim usually means carved idols.
- k (3:22) The meaning of the rare Hebrew word parshedon is uncertain. The Septuagint (B text) lacks this clause.
- l (3:23) The meaning of the rare Hebrew word misderon is uncertain; perhaps "vestibule" or "latrine."
- m (3:24) Hebrew "covering his feet," a polite expression.
- n (3:31) Anath was a Canaanite goddess of war; "son of Anath" may refer to Shamgar's town (Beth-anath) or describe him as a warrior.

Chapter 4

1 After Ehud died, the Israelites again did what was evil in the eyes
of Yahweh. 2 So Yahweh sold them into the hand of Jabin[a] king of
Canaan, who reigned in Hazor. The commander of his army was
Sisera, who lived in Harosheth-hagoyim.[b] 3 Then the Israelites cried
out to Yahweh, for he had nine hundred chariots of iron, and he had
oppressed the Israelites harshly for twenty years.
4 Now Deborah,[c] a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth,[d] was judging
Israel at that time. 5 She held court beneath Deborah's Palm, between
Ramah and Bethel in Ephraim's hill country, and Israelites came to
her for rulings. 6 She summoned Barak[e] son of Abinoam from Kedesh
in Naphtali and told him, "Yahweh, the God of Israel, commands
you: Go, assemble at Mount Tabor, bringing ten thousand men of

Naphtali and Zebulun. 7 I will lure Sisera, Jabin's army commander,
to the Kishon wadi to meet you, with his chariots and soldiers, and
I will give him to you.'" 8 Barak said to her, "If you will go with me,
I will go, but if you will not go with me, I will not go."[f] 9 She said,
"I will certainly go with you. Nevertheless, the road you are taking
will not lead to your glory, for Yahweh will sell Sisera into the hand
of a woman." Then Deborah arose and went with Barak to Kedesh. 10
Barak summoned Zebulun and Naphtali to assemble at Kedesh. Ten
thousand men marched out behind him,[g] and Deborah went along
as well.
11 Heber the Kenite had split off from the other Kenites, who
descended from Hobab, Moses' brother-in-law. He had set up his tent
far off, by the great tree at Zaanannim,[h] close to Kedesh.
12 When Sisera was told that Barak son of Abinoam had gone up to
Mount Tabor, 13 Sisera called out all his chariots, nine hundred char-
iots of iron, and all the people who were with him, from Harosheth-
hagoyim to the Kishon River. 14 Deborah urged Barak, "Go! This very
day Yahweh hands Sisera over to you. Isn't Yahweh marching ahead
of you?" So Barak descended Mount Tabor, ten thousand men behind
him. 15 And Yahweh threw Sisera and all his chariots and all his army
into panic before Barak by the edge of the sword. Sisera got down
from his chariot and fled on foot. 16 Barak chased the chariots and the
troops as far as Harosheth-haggoyim, and Sisera's whole army was
put to the sword. Not a single man survived.
17 But Sisera fled on foot to the tent of Jael,[i] the wife of Heber the
Kenite, for there was peace between Jabin king of Hazor and the
house of Heber the Kenite. 18 Jael went out to greet Sisera and told
him, "Come in, sir, come in with me; have no fear." He went into her
tent, and she hid him under a blanket. 19 He asked her, "May I have a
sip of water? I am parched." She opened a milk skin, gave him a drink,
and covered him up again. 20 He said to her, "Stand at the entrance
of the tent, and if anyone comes and asks you, 'Is anyone here?' say,
'No.'" 21 Then Heber's wife Jael took a tent peg and a mallet. She crept
up to him and hammered the peg through his skull into the ground,
as he lay in a deep sleep of exhaustion. And he died.[j] 22 And just then,

as Barak was pursuing Sisera, Jael came out to meet him and said to him, "Come, and I will show you the man you are looking for." So he went in with her, and there was Sisera lying dead, with the tent peg in his temple.

23 So on that day God subdued Jabin king of Canaan before the Israelites. 24 The Israelites' grip on Jabin, the king of Canaan, grew steadily stronger, until at last they wiped him out.

Notes

- a (4:2) Jabin means "he understands." A king of Hazor of the same name appears in Joshua 11:1.
- b (4:2) Harosheth-hagoyim perhaps means "woodland of the nations" or "cultivated land of the nations."
- c (4:4) Deborah means "bee."
- d (4:4) Or "a woman of fire" or "a fiery woman." Lappidoth means "torches," and may be a name or a description.
- e (4:6) Barak means "lightning." Abinoam means "my father is pleasantness."
- f (4:8) The Septuagint adds: "for I do not know the day on which the angel of Yahweh will give me success."
- g (4:10) Hebrew "at his feet," that is, following him; also in verse 15 of chapter 5.
- h (4:11) Or "the oak of Zaanannim." The Septuagint reads "the oak of the covetous ones." Hobab is perhaps the same person as Jethro (Exodus 3:1) or a son of Reuel (Numbers 10:29); the Hebrew word for "father-in-law" can also mean "brother-in-law."
- i (4:17) Jael means "mountain goat."
- j (4:21) Or "he was fast asleep and exhausted. So he died." The Hebrew is difficult. The Septuagint reads "and he fainted away, and darkness fell upon him, and he died."

Chapter 5

1 Then Deborah and Barak son of Abinoam sang on that day: 2 "When locks hang loose[a] in Israel, when the people offer themselves willingly, bless Yahweh! 3 Hear, O kings; listen, O rulers! I, to Yahweh I will sing; I will make music to Yahweh, the God of Israel. 4 Yahweh, as you came out of Seir, as you strode from Edom's fields, the earth shook, the skies poured rain, the clouds dripped water. 5 The mountains quaked[b] before Yahweh, the One of Sinai,[c] before Yahweh, the God of Israel.

6 In Shamgar son of Anath's time, in Jael's time, the main roads stood
empty,[d] and caravans took the byways. 7 Village life[e] ceased in Israel;
it ceased until I, Deborah, arose,[f] until I arose, a mother in Israel. 8
They chose new gods; then war was in the gates.[g] Was a shield or a
spear to be seen among forty thousand in Israel? 9 My heart goes out
to the commanders of Israel, those who offered themselves willingly
among the people. Bless Yahweh! 10 You who ride on white[h] donkeys,
you who sit on rich carpets,[i] and you who walk on the road, tell of it!
[j] 11 Louder than the voice of the archers[k] at the watering places, there
they recount the righteous acts of Yahweh, the righteous acts of his
villagers in Israel. Then the people of Yahweh went down to the gates.
12 "Awake, awake, Deborah! Awake, awake, sing a song! Arise, Barak,
and take your captives captive, son of Abinoam. 13 Then the survivors
came down to the nobles; the people of Yahweh came down for
me against the mighty.[l] 14 From Ephraim came those whose root is
in Amalek;[m] after you, Benjamin, with your kinsmen. From Machir
came down commanders, and from Zebulun those who carry the
officer's staff.[n] 15 Issachar's chieftains marched with Deborah, and
Issachar stood by Barak; they plunged into the valley on his heels.
Among Reuben's divisions there was much soul-searching.[o] 16 Why
did you linger among the sheep pens,[p] listening to shepherds pipe to
their flocks? Among Reuben's divisions there was much hesitation. 17
Gilead remained across the Jordan; and Dan, why did he loiter near
the ships?[q] Asher stayed on the seashore and lingered in his harbors.
18 Zebulun's people risked their lives, facing death; and Naphtali too,
on the open hills.
19 "Kings came; they fought; then the kings of Canaan fought at
Taanach, by the waters of Megiddo. They took no plunder of silver. 20
From heaven the stars fought; from their courses they fought against
Sisera. 21 The river Kishon carried them off, that ancient[r] river, the
Kishon. Advance, my spirit, with might![s] 22 Then the horses' hooves
hammered with the galloping, the galloping of his mighty steeds. 23
'Curse Meroz,'[t] said Yahweh's messenger, 'curse her people bitterly,
for they never came to aid Yahweh, to aid Yahweh against the
warriors.'

24 “Most blessed of women is Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite; of
women in tents she is most blessed. 25 He asked for water; she gave
him milk; in a bowl fit for nobles she brought him curds. 26 She put her
hand to the tent peg and her right hand to the workman’s hammer.
She struck Sisera; she crushed his head; she shattered and pierced his
temple. 27 At her feet he crumpled, collapsed, and lay still; at her feet
he crumpled and fell; right where he crumpled, he lay dead.
28 “At the window she peered out and cried, Sisera’s mother, from
behind the lattice: ‘Why is his chariot delayed? Why is the sound of
his chariot wheels so late?’ 29 The wisest of her ladies answer her;
indeed, she repeats her own words to herself: 30 ‘Are they not finding
and dividing the spoil? A girl, two girls[u] for every man; spoil of dyed
cloth for Sisera, spoil of dyed cloth embroidered, dyed cloth, doubly
embroidered, for the neck of the plunderer?’[v]
31 “So may all your enemies perish, O Yahweh! But may those who
love him be like the sun when it rises in its might.” And the land had
rest forty years.

Notes

- a (5:2) Or “When leaders take the lead.” The Hebrew phrase bifroaʿ peraʿot is one of many difficult expressions in this ancient poem. It may refer to warriors letting their hair hang loose as a sign of dedication (compare Numbers 6:5), or to leaders taking command. The Septuagint (B text) reads “When a revelation was made in Israel”; other Greek manuscripts understand it of rulers taking command.
- b (5:5) Or “flowed” or “melted.” The Hebrew may come from a verb meaning “quake” (as the Septuagint, “were shaken”) or from one meaning “flow.”
- c (5:5) Or “this is Sinai,” or “even Sinai.” Many scholars take Hebrew zeh sinai as an ancient title, “the One of Sinai” (compare Psalm 68:8).
- d (5:6) Or “caravans ceased.”
- e (5:7) Or “Warriors.” The meaning of Hebrew perazon (also in verse 11) is uncertain; it may mean the people of unwalled villages, or rulers or warriors. The Septuagint (B text) reads “the mighty men.”
- f (5:7) Or “until you arose, Deborah, until you arose.” The Hebrew form qamti can be read as an old second-person form, which the Septuagint follows (“until Deborah arose”).
- g (5:8) The Hebrew of this line is very difficult. The Septuagint (B text) agrees with “They chose new gods”; some translators read “God chose new leaders.” The second clause is also uncertain (“then there was fighting in the gates,” or “then there was bread of barley”).

- h (5:10) Or “tawny.” The Septuagint (B text) reads “at noonday,” taking the Hebrew word as tsohorayim.
- i (5:10) The meaning of Hebrew middin is uncertain; perhaps “saddle blankets.” The Septuagint (B text) reads “on the judgment seat,” relating it to the word for “judgment.”
- j (5:10) Or “consider it!” or “sing of it!”
- k (5:11) Or “of those who divide the flocks,” or “of the musicians.” The meaning of Hebrew mechatsetsim is uncertain. The Septuagint (B text) reads “from the noise of disturbers among the drawers of water.”
- l (5:13) The Hebrew of verse 13 is difficult and has been read in several ways. The Septuagint (B text) reads “Then the remnant went down to the strong; the people of Yahweh went down for him among the mighty from me.”
- m (5:14) The meaning is uncertain; perhaps Ephraim had settled in land once held by Amalek (compare 12:15). The Septuagint (B text) reads “Ephraim rooted them out in Amalek.”
- n (5:14) Or “the staff of the scribe,” or “the rod of the marshal.” Hebrew shebet sopher.
- o (5:15) Hebrew chiqqe-leb, “decisions of heart.” Many Hebrew manuscripts and the parallel line in verse 16 read chiqre-leb, “searchings of heart,” a difference of one letter. The Septuagint (B text) reads “great pangs reached to the heart.”
- p (5:16) Or “saddlebags” or “campfires.” The meaning of Hebrew mishpetayim is uncertain.
- q (5:17) Or “why did he serve as an alien on ships?” The Hebrew verb gur means to stay as a resident alien.
- r (5:21) The meaning of Hebrew qedumim is uncertain; perhaps “ancient,” or “onrushing,” or “of battles.”
- s (5:21) Or “You trampled the strong, O my soul!” The Septuagint (B text) reads “my mighty soul will trample him down.”
- t (5:23) The location of Meroz is unknown.
- u (5:30) Hebrew “a womb, two wombs,” a crude soldiers’ term for captive women.
- v (5:30) The Hebrew of the last line is difficult; some read “for my neck as plunder,” or “for the neck of the queen.” The Septuagint (B text) has “he will surely be gracious to every man … they are the spoils for his neck.”

Chapter 6

1 The Israelites did what was evil in the eyes of Yahweh, and Yahweh
gave them into the hand of Midian seven years. 2 The hand of
Midian prevailed over Israel. Because of Midian the Israelites made
for themselves the dens that are in the mountains, and the caves and
the strongholds. 3 For whenever Israel had sown seed, Midian and
Amalek and the people of the east would come up and attack them. 4

They would camp against them and destroy the produce of the land as far as Gaza, and they left no sustenance in Israel, neither sheep nor ox nor donkey. 5 They arrived with their herds and tents, as numerous as locusts. They and their camels were beyond counting, and they invaded the land to devastate it. 6 So Israel was brought very low because of Midian, and the Israelites cried out to Yahweh.
7 When the Israelites cried out to Yahweh on account of Midian,[a] 8 Yahweh sent a prophet to the Israelites, who told them, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'I rescued you from Egypt and freed you from the house of slavery. 9 I rescued you from the hand of the Egyptians and from the hand of all who oppressed you. I drove them out before you and gave you their land. 10 I told you, "I am Yahweh your God; do not worship the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you live." But you ignored me.'"
11 The messenger of Yahweh arrived and sat beneath the oak tree in Ophrah, a town of Joash, from the clan of Abiezer. Joash's son Gideon[b] was threshing wheat inside a winepress, to keep it out of Midian's sight. 12 The angel of Yahweh appeared to him and said to him, "Yahweh is with you, mighty warrior." 13 Gideon replied, "Please, sir, if Yahweh is with us, why has all this disaster come upon us? Where are the marvels our ancestors described to us, saying, 'Didn't Yahweh lead us out of Egypt?' But now Yahweh has deserted us and handed us over to Midian." 14 Yahweh turned to him and said, "Go, with all the strength you possess, and deliver Israel from Midian's grip. Am I not the one sending you?" 15 He said to him, "Please, Lord, how can I save Israel? Look, my clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the least in my father's house." 16 Yahweh answered him, "I will be with you, and you will defeat Midian as though it were a single man." 17 He said to him, "If I have found favor in your eyes, then give me a sign that it is you who are speaking with me. 18 Please stay here until I come back with my gift and set it down in front of you." He answered, "I will wait until you come back."
19 So Gideon went in and prepared a young goat, and unleavened cakes from about three-fifths of a bushel[c] of flour. He put the meat in a basket and the broth in a pot, and brought them out to him under

the oak and presented them. 20 The angel of God said to him, “Take
the meat and the unleavened cakes, put them on this rock, and pour
out the broth.” And he did so. 21 Then the angel of Yahweh reached
out the tip of the staff that was in his hand and touched the meat and
the unleavened cakes. Fire went up from the rock and consumed the
meat and the unleavened cakes. And the angel of Yahweh vanished
from his sight. 22 Then Gideon saw that he was the angel of Yahweh.
And Gideon said, “Alas, Lord Yahweh! For I have seen the angel of
Yahweh face to face.” 23 But Yahweh said to him, “Peace be to you. Do
not be afraid; you will not die.” 24 So Gideon built an altar there to
Yahweh and called it Yahweh Shalom.[d] To this day it still stands at
Ophrah of the Abiezrites.
25 The same night Yahweh instructed him, “Take your father’s second
bull, a seven-year-old,[e] Demolish your father’s altar to Baal, and chop
down the Asherah pole[f] beside it. 26 Then build an altar to Yahweh
your God on the top of this stronghold, laid out in proper order.
Take the second bull and offer it as a burnt offering with the wood
of the Asherah that you cut down.” 27 So Gideon took ten men from
his servants and did as Yahweh had told him. But because he was too
afraid of his father’s household and the men of the city to do it by
day, he did it by night.
28 When the townsmen got up early next morning, they saw Baal’s
altar demolished, the Asherah pole beside it hacked down, and the
second bull offered on a newly built altar. 29 They said to one another,
“Who has done this thing?” When they had inquired and searched,
they said, “Gideon son of Joash has done this thing.” 30 The townsmen
demanded of Joash, “Hand over your son for execution! He demol-
ished Baal’s altar and chopped down the Asherah pole next to it.” 31
But Joash said to all who stood against him, “Will you contend for
Baal? Will you save him? Whoever contends for him will be put to
death by morning. If he is a god, let him contend for himself, because
someone has torn down his altar.” 32 So on that day Gideon was called
Jerubbaal,[g] that is to say, “Let Baal contend against him,” because he
tore down his altar.

33 Then all of Midian, Amalek, and the eastern peoples joined forces,
crossed the Jordan, and encamped in the Jezreel Valley. 34 But the Spirit
of Yahweh clothed[h] Gideon, and he sounded the ram's horn, and the
Abiezrites were called out to follow him. 35 He dispatched messengers
across the territory of Manasseh, calling its men to arms behind him.
He also sent word to Asher, Zebulun, and Naphtali, and those tribes
marched out to join them.
36 Then Gideon said to God, "If you will save Israel by my hand, as you
have said, 37 watch, I will put out a wool fleece on the threshing floor.
If dew gathers only on the fleece while the surrounding earth stays
dry, I will be sure that you plan to save Israel through my action, as
you promised." 38 And so it happened. He got up early the next day,
wrung out the fleece, and squeezed out a bowlful of dew. 39 Gideon
pleaded with God, "Please don't be furious with me, but let me ask
once more. Allow me one more test with the fleece: this time let the
fleece alone stay dry, and let dew cover the ground around it." 40 God
did that during the night. Only the fleece was dry, while the ground
all around was covered with dew.

Notes

- a (6:7) The Dead Sea Scroll 4QJudg[a], one of the oldest surviving manuscripts of Judges, lacks verses 7–10; its text passes directly from verse 6 to verse 11. Many scholars regard these verses, which are present in the Masoretic Text and the Septuagint, as a later addition to the story.
- b (6:11) Gideon probably means "hacker" or "one who cuts down" (compare verses 25–32). Joash means "Yahweh has given." Ophrah perhaps means "fawn."
- c (6:19) Hebrew "an ephah," about 22 liters (L).
- d (6:24) Yahweh Shalom means "Yahweh is peace."
- e (6:25) The Hebrew is difficult; perhaps "the young bull of your father, and a second bull seven years old." The Septuagint (B text) agrees with the Hebrew: "the young bullock … even the second bullock of seven years old."
- f (6:25) A wooden pole or image associated with the goddess Asherah; also in verses 26, 28, and 30.
- g (6:32) Jerubbaal means "Let Baal contend." In 2 Samuel 11:21 the name is changed to Jerubbesheth, replacing Baal with bosheth, "shame."
- h (6:34) That is, took possession of him; Hebrew "put on Gideon like a garment."

Chapter 7

1 Early next morning Jerubbaal (that is, Gideon) and his whole army
set up camp at the spring of Harod.[a] Midian's camp lay to the north,
beneath Moreh hill,[b] in the valley.
2 Yahweh said to Gideon, "The people who are with you are too many
for me to give Midian into their hand, or Israel would boast against
me, saying, 'My own hand has saved me.' 3 So now, proclaim in the
hearing of the people, 'Whoever is fearful and trembling, let him turn
back and leave Mount Gilead.'"[c] Then twenty-two thousand of the
people turned back, and ten thousand remained.
4 Yahweh told Gideon, "You still have too many men. Lead them down
to the water, and I will sort them out there for you. Of anyone I say,
'This man goes with you,' that man goes; of anyone I say, 'This man
does not go with you,' that man stays behind." 5 So he brought the
people down to the water, and Yahweh said to Gideon, "Everyone
who laps the water with his tongue, as a dog laps, you shall set by
himself; likewise everyone who kneels down to drink." 6 The number
of those who lapped, putting their hand to their mouths,[d] was three
hundred men, and all the rest of the people knelt down to drink water.
7 Yahweh said to Gideon, "With the three hundred men who lapped I
will save you and give Midian into your hand. Let all the rest of the
people go, each to his home." 8 So they took the people's provisions
in their hand, and their ram's horns, and he sent all the rest of the
men of Israel each to his tent, but he kept the three hundred men.
The camp of Midian was below him in the valley.
9 That same night Yahweh said to him, "Get up, go down against the
camp, for I have given it into your hand. 10 If you are afraid to attack,
go down to the camp with your servant Purah. 11 You will listen to
their talk, and after that you will find the nerve to attack the camp."
So he and his servant Purah crept down to where the armed sentries
were posted at the camp's edge. 12 The Midianites, Amalekites, and
all the eastern peoples had spread across the valley like a swarm of
locusts, and their camels were as countless as the sand along the
seashore. 13 When Gideon arrived, there was a man telling his comrade
a dream. He said, "Look, I had a dream, and there was a round loaf

of barley bread tumbling into the camp of Midian. It came to the tent
and struck it so that it fell, and turned it upside down, and the tent
collapsed." 14 His companion replied, "That can only mean the sword
of Gideon, the Israelite son of Joash. God has delivered Midian, and
the entire army with it, into his power."
15 When Gideon heard the dream described and explained, he knelt in
worship. He went back to Israel's camp and called, "Rise! Yahweh has
put the Midianite camp in your power." 16 He split the three hundred
men into three divisions. He gave every man a ram's horn and an
empty jar, with a torch burning in each jar. 17 He said to them, "Watch
me and do the same. When I come to the edge of the camp, do as I do.
18 When I and all who are with me blow the ram's horn, then you also
blow the ram's horns all around the camp and shout, 'For Yahweh
and for Gideon!'"
19 Gideon and his hundred men reached the camp's perimeter at the
start of the middle watch (about ten at night),[e] just after the sentries
had been changed. They blew their horns and smashed the jars they
were holding. 20 The three companies blew the ram's horns and broke
the jars. They held the torches in their left hands and the ram's horns
in their right hands to blow, and they cried out, "A sword for Yahweh
and for Gideon!" 21 Each man stood in his place around the camp, and
all the camp ran; they cried out and fled. 22 When the three hundred
horns sounded, Yahweh turned every man's sword against his fellow
soldier throughout the camp. The army fled toward Beth-shittah
and on to Zererah, to the border of Abel-meholah near Tabbath. 23
Israelites from Naphtali, Asher, and all of Manasseh were called up
and joined the chase after Midian.
24 Gideon dispatched messengers across Ephraim's hill country with
this order: "Come down and attack Midian! Seize the fords of the Jor-
dan before they reach them, as far as Beth-barah." All the Ephraimite
men were called up, and they held the fords as far as Beth-barah, and
the Jordan itself. 25 They captured two Midianite commanders, Oreb
and Zeeb.[f] Oreb they killed on the rock that bears his name, and Zeeb
at the winepress called after him. They kept chasing Midian, then
carried the heads of Oreb and Zeeb across the Jordan to Gideon.

Notes

- a (7:1) Harod means "trembling" (compare verse 3).
- b (7:1) Moreh means "teacher" or "one who gives oracles."
- c (7:3) Gilead lies east of the Jordan, far from Gideon's camp; many scholars suspect an early copying error, perhaps for Mount Gilboa, or take the Hebrew verb (found only here) to mean "and hurry away from Mount Gilead."
- d (7:6) In the Hebrew the words "putting their hand to their mouths" stand in verse 6 with those who lapped; the Septuagint (B text) agrees. Some scholars think the phrase originally belonged at the end of verse 5 with those who knelt.
- e (7:19) Hebrew "the middle watch." In the Old Testament the night was divided into three watches: evening (until about 10 p.m.), middle (until about 2 a.m.), and morning (until about 6 a.m.).
- f (7:25) Oreb means "raven," and Zeeb means "wolf."

Chapter 8

1 The Ephraimites demanded of Gideon, "Why did you treat us this
way? You never called us when you set out to fight Midian!" They
berated him harshly. 2 He said to them, "What have I done now in
comparison with you? Is not the gleaning of the grapes of Ephraim
better than the grape harvest of Abiezer? 3 God handed Midian's
commanders, Oreb and Zeeb, over to you. What could I possibly
accomplish next to you?" When he said this, their resentment cooled.
4 Gideon came to the Jordan and crossed over, he and the three
hundred men who were with him, exhausted yet pursuing. 5 He said
to the men of Succoth,[a] "Please give loaves of bread to the people
who follow me, for they are exhausted, and I am pursuing Zebah and
Zalmunna,[b] the kings of Midian." 6 But the officials of Succoth said,
"Are the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna already in your hand, that
we should give bread to your army?" 7 Gideon said, "Because of this,
when Yahweh has given Zebah and Zalmunna into my hand, I will
thresh[c] your flesh with the thorns of the wilderness and with briers."
8 From there he went up to Penuel[d] and spoke to them in the same
way, and the men of Penuel answered him as the men of Succoth had
answered. 9 He warned the men of Penuel, "When I return victorious,
I will demolish this tower."
10 Now Zebah and Zalmunna were in Karkor, and their army with
them, about fifteen thousand men, all who were left of the whole

army of the people of the east; for those who had fallen were a hundred and twenty thousand men who drew the sword. 11 Gideon took the caravan route east of Nobah and Jogbehah and attacked the enemy camp, which was off its guard. 12 Zebah and Zalmunna fled, and he pursued them. He captured the two kings of Midian, Zebah and Zalmunna, and threw the whole army into panic.
13 Then Gideon son of Joash returned from the battle by the Ascent of Heres.[e] 14 He captured a young man of the men of Succoth and questioned him, and the young man wrote down for him the officials of Succoth and its elders, seventy-seven men. 15 Then he came to the men of Succoth and said, "Here are Zebah and Zalmunna, about whom you taunted me, saying, 'Are the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna already in your hand, that we should give bread to your exhausted men?'" 16 He seized the town's elders, gathered thorn bushes and thistles from the wilderness, and used them to give the men of Succoth a painful lesson.[f] 17 He tore down the tower of Penuel and killed the men of the city.
18 Then he said to Zebah and Zalmunna, "What kind of men were they whom you killed at Tabor?" They said, "As you are, so were they, each one resembling the son of a king." 19 He said, "They were my brothers, the sons of my mother. As Yahweh lives, if you had let them live, I would not kill you." 20 He said to Jether his firstborn, "Get up, kill them!" But the young man did not draw his sword, for he was afraid, because he was still a young man. 21 Zebah and Zalmunna replied, "Do it yourself, strike us down, for a man's strength matches his years." Gideon stood up, killed Zebah and Zalmunna, and removed the crescent ornaments from their camels' necks.
22 The Israelites told Gideon, "Be our ruler, you, then your son, and then your grandson, since you rescued us from Midian's power." 23 Gideon said to them, "I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you. Yahweh will rule over you." 24 Then Gideon told them, "I have one request: each of you, hand over the earrings you took as plunder." (The enemy wore gold earrings, as Ishmaelites did.[g]) 25 They said, "We will gladly give them." So they spread out a garment, and every man threw on it the earrings from his spoil. 26 The gold earrings

he had requested weighed about forty-three pounds,[h] not counting
the crescent ornaments, pendants, and purple robes worn by Midian's
kings, or the chains around the camels' necks. 27 Gideon made it into
an ephod[i] and put it in his city, in Ophrah. And all Israel prostituted
themselves after it there, and it became a snare to Gideon and to his
house. 28 So Midian was subdued before the Israelites, and they did
not raise their heads again. And the land had rest forty years in the
days of Gideon.
29 Jerubbaal son of Joash went and lived in his own house. 30 Gideon
had seventy sons, his own offspring,[j] for he had many wives. 31 His
concubine who was in Shechem also bore him a son, and he named
him Abimelech.[k] 32 Gideon son of Joash died at a ripe old age and
was buried in his father Joash's tomb at Ophrah, the town of the
Abiezrites.
33 As soon as Gideon died, the Israelites turned again and prostituted
themselves after the Baals, and they made Baal-berith[l] their god. 34
The Israelites did not remember Yahweh their God, who had rescued
them from the hand of all their enemies on every side, 35 and they
did not show kindness to the house of Jerubbaal (that is, Gideon) in
return for all the good that he had done for Israel.

Notes

- a (8:5) Succoth means "booths" or "shelters."
- b (8:5) Zebah means "sacrifice," and Zalmunna perhaps "protection withheld." The names may be deliberate distortions of the kings' real names.
- c (8:7) Or "tear." The Septuagint (B text) reads "tear your flesh with the thorns of the wilderness and the Barkenim," keeping the Hebrew word for "briers" as a name.
- d (8:8) Penuel means "face of God" (Genesis 32:30).
- e (8:13) Or "from the battle before sunrise." Heres means "sun."
- f (8:16) So the Hebrew, "made to know." Many scholars read "threshed" (compare verse 7), a slight difference in the Hebrew letters; the Septuagint (B text) reads "tore."
- g (8:24) Here a general term for desert traders. Compare Genesis 37:25–28, where Ishmaelites and Midianites are mentioned together.
- h (8:26) Hebrew "1,700 shekels," about 19.5 kilograms (kg).
- i (8:27) An ephod was a priestly garment (Exodus 28:6–14), but here it seems to be an object used in worship or for seeking oracles.
- j (8:30) Hebrew "who came out of his thigh."

- k (8:31) Abimelech means “my father is king.”
- l (8:33) Baal-berith means “lord of the covenant.” Compare El-berith in 9:46.

Chapter 9

1 Abimelech, Jerubbaal’s son, traveled to Shechem, to his mother’s
brothers, and addressed them and his mother’s whole extended
family: 2 “Put this question to all of Shechem’s leaders:[a] ‘Which would
you prefer, rule by seventy men, all of Jerubbaal’s sons, or rule by a
single man? Remember that I am your own flesh and blood.’” 3 His
mother’s brothers repeated his proposal to every one of Shechem’s
leading citizens, and their loyalties swung toward Abimelech, since
they reasoned, “He is our own flesh and blood.” 4 They gave him
seventy pieces of silver[b] from the house of Baal-berith, and with it
Abimelech hired worthless and reckless men, who followed him. 5 He
went to his father’s house at Ophrah and killed his brothers, the sons
of Jerubbaal, seventy men, on one stone. But Jotham,[c] the youngest
son of Jerubbaal, was left, for he hid himself. 6 Then all the leaders of
Shechem and all Beth-millo[d] gathered together and went and made
Abimelech king by the oak of the pillar[e] at Shechem.
7 When Jotham was told, he went and stood on the top of Mount
Gerizim and raised his voice and called out to them: “Listen to me,
leaders of Shechem, so that God may listen to you. 8 The trees once
went out to anoint a king over themselves. They said to the olive tree,
‘Reign over us.’ 9 But the olive tree said to them, ‘Should I give up my
rich oil, by which gods and people are honored, and go to sway over
the trees?’ 10 Then the trees said to the fig tree, ‘You come and reign
over us.’ 11 But the fig tree answered, ‘Am I to abandon my sweet, rich
fruit and go off to wave above the other trees?’ 12 Then the trees said
to the vine, ‘You come and reign over us.’ 13 But the vine said to them,
‘Should I give up my new wine, which cheers gods and people, and
go to sway over the trees?’ 14 Then all the trees said to the bramble,
‘You come and reign over us.’ 15 And the bramble said to the trees, ‘If
you are truly anointing me king over you, then come and take refuge
in my shade. But if not, let fire come out of the bramble and consume
the cedars of Lebanon.’

16 "Now consider: did you behave honestly and sincerely when you
crowned Abimelech? Have you treated Jerubbaal and his family
fairly, and repaid him in keeping with what he did? 17 for my father
fought for you and risked his life and rescued you from the hand of
Midian, 18 and you have risen up against my father's house today and
killed his sons, seventy men, on one stone, and have made Abimelech,
the son of his slave woman, king over the leaders of Shechem, because
he is your brother— 19 if you have indeed dealt honestly and sincerely
with Jerubbaal and his family today, then enjoy Abimelech, and may
he enjoy you too. 20 If not, may fire blaze out from Abimelech and
devour Shechem's leaders and Beth-millo, and may fire blaze out
from Shechem's leaders and Beth-millo and devour Abimelech." 21
Then Jotham ran away and fled and went to Beer,[f] and he lived there
because of Abimelech his brother.
22 Abimelech ruled over Israel three years. 23 Then God sent an evil
spirit between Abimelech and the leaders of Shechem, and the leaders
of Shechem dealt treacherously with Abimelech, 24 This was to bring
retribution for the violence against Jerubbaal's seventy sons, laying
their blood on their brother Abimelech, who murdered them, and on
the Shechemite leaders, who had backed him in killing his brothers. 25
The leading men of Shechem stationed ambushers for him along the
mountain summits, and they plundered every traveler on that route.
Abimelech was told about it.
26 Gaal, Ebed's son,[g] arrived with his brothers and settled in Shechem,
and the city's leading men came to trust him. 27 They went to the
countryside, harvested their vineyards, trampled the grapes, and
held a celebration.[h] In the temple of their god they feasted, drank,
and cursed Abimelech. 28 Gaal son of Ebed said, "Who is Abimelech,
and who is Shechem, that we should serve him? Is he not the son
of Jerubbaal, and is not Zebul his officer? Serve the men of Hamor,
the father of Shechem! But why should we serve him? 29 If only
I commanded this people! I would remove Abimelech." He taunted
Abimelech,[i] "Build up your forces and come out to battle!"
30 When Zebul the ruler of the city heard the words of Gaal son of
Ebed, his anger burned. 31 He sent messengers to Abimelech in secret,[j]

with this message: “Gaal, Ebed’s son, and his brothers have arrived in Shechem, where they are turning the city against you. 32 So now, get up by night, you and the people who are with you, and lie in ambush in the field. 33 At sunrise tomorrow, be up early and storm the town. When he and his men march out against you, deal with them as the opportunity allows.”
34 So Abimelech and all the people who were with him got up by night and lay in ambush against Shechem in four companies. 35 Gaal son of Ebed went out and took his stand at the town gate’s entrance. Abimelech and his troops emerged from their hiding place. 36 Gaal spotted the troops and said to Zebul, “Look, men are descending from the mountaintops!” Zebul answered, “Those are just the shadows of the hills, which look like men.” 37 Gaal spoke again and said, “Look, people are coming down from the center of the land,[k] and one company is coming by the way of the Diviners’ Oak.”[l] 38 Zebul retorted, “Where is your big talk now? You asked, ‘Who is Abimelech, that we must serve him?’ Aren’t these the very men you sneered at? Go on out and fight them.” 39 So Gaal went out at the head of the leaders of Shechem and fought against Abimelech. 40 Abimelech chased him, and he fled before him, and many fell wounded, up to the entrance of the gate. 41 Abimelech remained in Arumah, and Zebul expelled Gaal and his kinsmen from Shechem, so that they could no longer live there.
42 On the next day the people went out into the field, and Abimelech was told. 43 He divided the troops into three companies and hid them in the fields. When he saw the citizens emerging from the town, he sprang up, attacked them, and cut them down. 44 Abimelech and the companies that were with him rushed forward and stood at the entrance of the city gate, while the two companies rushed upon all who were in the field and struck them down. 45 Abimelech fought against the city all that day. He captured the city and killed the people who were in it, and he tore down the city and sowed it with salt.
46 When all the leaders of the Tower of Shechem heard of it, they went into the stronghold[m] of the house of El-berith.[n] 47 Abimelech was told that all the leaders of the Tower of Shechem had gathered together. 48 So Abimelech went up to Mount Zalmon,[o] he and all the people who

were with him. Abimelech took an axe in his hand, cut down a bundle of brushwood, lifted it up, and put it on his shoulder. He said to the people who were with him, “What you have seen me do, hurry and do as I have done.” 49 Each of the soldiers likewise chopped down a branch and followed Abimelech. They piled the branches against the tower and set it ablaze with the people inside, so that everyone in the Shechem Tower died, about a thousand men and women.
50 Then Abimelech went to Thebez, camped against Thebez, and captured it. 51 Inside the town stood a fortified tower, and every man and woman, the town’s leaders included, fled into it, locked the door behind them, and climbed onto the tower’s roof. 52 Abimelech came to the tower and fought against it, and he drew near to the door of the tower to burn it with fire. 53 But a certain woman threw an upper millstone on Abimelech’s head and crushed his skull. 54 He shouted urgently to his armor-bearer, “Pull out your blade and finish me off, or they will say about me, ‘A woman killed him!’” The servant ran him through, and Abimelech was dead. 55 When the men of Israel saw that Abimelech was dead, they went each to his home.
56 In this way God paid Abimelech back for the crime he had committed against his father by murdering seventy brothers. 57 God also paid back the Shechemites for all their wickedness, and Jotham son of Jerubbaal’s curse fell upon them.

Notes

- a (9:2) Or “citizens” or “lords”; Hebrew ba‘ale, plural of baal, “owner, lord.” So throughout this chapter.
- b (9:4) Hebrew “seventy of silver,” probably shekels, about 1¾ pounds (800 grams, g).
- c (9:5) Jotham means “Yahweh is perfect.”
- d (9:6) Beth-millo means “house of the fill,” probably a fortified structure built on an earth platform.
- e (9:6) Hebrew elon mutstsab. The Septuagint (B text) reads “by the oak of the station” and adds a second rendering of the same Hebrew word (“of the finder”); the A text lacks the addition.
- f (9:21) Beer means “well.”
- g (9:26) Gaal perhaps means “loathing,” and Ebed means “servant” or “slave.” The Septuagint (B text) reads “Gaal son of Jobel.”

- h (9:27) Hebrew hillulim, a festival of praise held at the grape harvest. The Septuagint (B text) keeps the Hebrew word ("made ellulim"); the A text reads "made dances."
- i (9:29) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint reads "I would say to Abimelech."
- j (9:31) Or "at Tormah." The meaning of Hebrew betormah, found only here, is uncertain; some read "at Arumah" (verse 41).
- k (9:37) Hebrew "the navel of the land."
- l (9:37) Hebrew elon me'onenim. The Septuagint (B text) keeps the Hebrew words as a name; the A text translates them, "the way of the oak of the seers."
- m (9:46) Or "inner chamber." The meaning of Hebrew tseriach is uncertain; also in verse 49.
- n (9:46) El-berith means "God of the covenant." Compare Baal-berith in 8:33 and 9:4.
- o (9:48) Zalmon means "dark" or "shady."

Chapter 10

1 After Abimelech, Tola son of Puah, son of Dodo, from the tribe
of Issachar, came forward to deliver Israel. He lived in Shamir in
Ephraim's hill country. 2 He judged Israel twenty-three years. Then
he died and was buried at Shamir.
3 After him rose Jair the Gileadite, who judged Israel twenty-two
years. 4 He had thirty sons who rode on thirty donkeys, and they had
thirty towns,[a] which are called Havvoth-jair[b] to this day; they are in
the land of Gilead. 5 And Jair died and was buried at Kamon.
6 The Israelites went back to doing evil in Yahweh's sight. They
worshiped the Baals and Ashtaroth and the deities of Aram, Sidon,
Moab, Ammon, and Philistia. They deserted Yahweh and no longer
served him. 7 So the anger of Yahweh burned against Israel, and he
sold them into the hand of the Philistines and into the hand of the
Ammonites, 8 and that year they crushed and battered the Israelites.
For eighteen years they tyrannized all the Israelites east of the Jordan
in Gilead, the Amorite country. 9 The Ammonites also crossed the
Jordan to fight against Judah, against Benjamin, and against the house
of Ephraim, so that Israel was in great distress.
10 Then the Israelites called to Yahweh for help: "We have wronged
you; we have forsaken our God and worshiped the Baals." 11 And
Yahweh said to the Israelites, "Did I not save you from the Egyptians,

from the Amorites, from the Ammonites, from the Philistines? 12 The Sidonians, Amalek, and Maon[c] oppressed you, and you cried out to me, and I saved you from their hand. 13 Yet you have abandoned me and served other gods; therefore I will no longer save you. 14 Off with you! Call on the gods you picked yourselves. Let them rescue you when you are in trouble." 15 The Israelites pleaded with Yahweh, "We have sinned. Treat us however you see fit; only deliver us today." 16 So they put away the foreign gods from among them and served Yahweh, and he could no longer bear the misery of Israel.[d]

17 Then the Ammonites were called to arms, and they camped in Gilead. And the Israelites gathered together and camped at Mizpah. 18 The people, the leaders of Gilead, said to one another, "Who is the man who will begin to fight against the Ammonites? He will be head over all the inhabitants of Gilead."

Notes

- a (10:4) There is a play on words in the Hebrew: ʿayarim means both "donkeys" and "towns."
- b (10:4) Havvoth-jair means "villages of Jair" (compare Numbers 32:41).
- c (10:12) The Septuagint reads "Midian."
- d (10:16) Hebrew "his soul was short with the misery of Israel," that is, he became impatient with their suffering.

Chapter 11

1 Jephthah[a] the Gileadite was a great warrior, though he was the son of a prostitute. His father was Gilead. 2 Gilead's wife also bore him sons. When his wife's sons grew up, they drove Jephthah out and said to him, "You will not have an inheritance in our father's house, for you are the son of another woman." 3 Jephthah ran away from his brothers and settled in Tob. A band of outlaws gathered around him and joined his raids.

4 After some time the Ammonites fought against Israel. 5 When Ammon went to war with Israel, Gilead's elders hurried to fetch Jephthah from Tob. 6 They told him, "Be our commander, and we will battle the Ammonites." 7 But Jephthah said to the elders of Gilead, "Did you not hate me and drive me out of my father's house? Why have you come to me now, when you are in distress?" 8 Gilead's elders

replied to Jephthah, “That is exactly why we are back. Come with us and fight the Ammonites, and you will govern everyone who lives in Gilead.” 9 Jephthah answered Gilead’s elders, “If you take me home to fight Ammon, and Yahweh delivers them to me, will I truly become your head?” 10 Gilead’s elders replied, “Yahweh is our witness; we will certainly do what you have said.” 11 So Jephthah went with the elders of Gilead, and the people made him head and commander over them. And Jephthah spoke all his words before Yahweh at Mizpah.

12 Then Jephthah sent messengers to the king of the Ammonites, saying, “What is there between you and me, that you have come to me to fight against my land?” 13 The king of the Ammonites said to the messengers of Jephthah, “Because Israel took away my land when they came up from Egypt, from the Arnon as far as the Jabbok and the Jordan. So now restore it peaceably.” 14 Jephthah again sent messengers to the king of the Ammonites 15 “This is what Jephthah says: Israel never seized Moabite or Ammonite land. 16 For when they came up from Egypt, Israel went through the wilderness to the Red Sea[b] and came to Kadesh. 17 Then Israel sent messengers to the king of Edom, saying, ‘Please let us pass through your land,’ but the king of Edom would not listen. They also sent to the king of Moab, but he was not willing. So Israel stayed at Kadesh. 18 Next they traveled through the desert, skirting Edom and Moab, reached the territory east of Moab, and encamped across the Arnon. They stayed out of Moabite land altogether, because the Arnon marked Moab’s frontier. 19 Israel then sent messengers to Sihon king of the Amorites, king of Heshbon, and Israel said to him, ‘Please let us pass through your land to our place.’ 20 But Sihon did not trust Israel to pass through his territory. So Sihon gathered all his people and camped at Jahaz and fought against Israel. 21 Yahweh, Israel’s God, delivered Sihon and his entire army to Israel, who defeated them. So Israel took over every acre belonging to the Amorites who lived there. 22 They seized the whole Amorite region: the Arnon marked its southern edge, the Jabbok its northern edge, the desert lay on the east, and the Jordan on the west. 23 So now Yahweh, the God of Israel, has dispossessed the Amorites before his people Israel; and are you to take possession of it? 24 Will you not

possess what Chemosh your god gives you to possess? And all that Yahweh our God has dispossessed before us, we will possess. 25 Are you any better than Balak son of Zippor, king of Moab? Did he ever pick a quarrel with Israel, or go to war with them? 26 Israel has lived in Heshbon and Aroer and their dependent villages, and in every town along the Arnon's banks, for three centuries. Why have you made no effort to retake them in all that time? 27 I have not sinned against you, but you are doing me wrong by fighting against me. May Yahweh, the Judge, decide today between the Israelites and the Ammonites." 28 The Ammonite king, however, ignored the message Jephthah had sent him.

29 Then Yahweh's Spirit took hold of Jephthah. He crossed Gilead and Manasseh, came to Mizpah in Gilead, and from there advanced against the Ammonites. 30 Jephthah made Yahweh a vow: "If you truly hand the Ammonites over to me, 31 then whatever[c] comes out of the doors of my house to meet me when I return in peace from the Ammonites will belong to Yahweh, and I will offer it up as a burnt offering." 32 So Jephthah crossed over to the Ammonites to fight against them, and Yahweh gave them into his hand. 33 He cut them down over a stretch from Aroer to the vicinity of Minnith, twenty towns, then on to Abel-keramim,[d] inflicting enormous losses. In this way Ammon was brought low beneath Israel.

34 When Jephthah reached his house in Mizpah, out ran his daughter to greet him, dancing and playing a hand drum. She was his only child; he had no son and no other daughter. 35 When he saw her, he tore his clothes and said, "Alas, my daughter! You have brought me very low, and you have become one of those who trouble me. For I have opened my mouth to Yahweh, and I cannot take it back." 36 She told him, "Father, you made a promise to Yahweh; do to me what you vowed, since Yahweh has avenged you on your enemies the Ammonites." 37 She added, "Grant me this one request: let me be for two months, so I can roam[e] the hills and mourn my virginity with my friends." 38 He said, "Go." And he sent her away for two months. She went with her companions and wept over her virginity on the mountains. 39 Two months later she came home to her father, and

he fulfilled the vow he had sworn. She never had relations with any man.[f] From this arose a custom in Israel 40 that the daughters of Israel went year by year to commemorate[g] the daughter of Jephthah the Gileadite four days in the year.

Notes

- a (11:1) Jephthah means "he opens" or "he sets free."
- b (11:16) Hebrew yam suf, literally "Sea of Reeds."
- c (11:31) Or "whoever." The Hebrew can refer to a person or an animal. Houses of the time often sheltered animals on the ground floor.
- d (11:33) Abel-keramim means "meadow of vineyards."
- e (11:37) So the Hebrew, "go down." Many scholars, with a small change of the Hebrew, read "wander."
- f (11:39) Some interpreters, ancient and modern, understand verses 39–40 to mean that Jephthah dedicated his daughter to lifelong virginity rather than offering her as a sacrifice; the plain sense of verse 31 is a burnt offering.
- g (11:40) Or "to lament" or "to recount the story of." The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain.

Chapter 12

1 The Ephraimite men were mobilized and crossed to Zaphon.[a] They confronted Jephthah: "Why did you march against the Ammonites without summoning us to join you? We will set fire to your house with you inside it!" 2 Jephthah answered, "My people and I were locked in a bitter struggle with the Ammonites. I appealed to you for help, but you never rescued me from them. 3 When I saw that you would not save me, I took my life in my hand and crossed over to the Ammonites, and Yahweh gave them into my hand. Why then have you come up to me this day to fight against me?" 4 Jephthah mustered all of Gilead's men and fought Ephraim. Gilead's men defeated Ephraim, who had taunted them: "You Gileadites are deserters from Ephraim, living between Ephraim and Manasseh."[b] 5 The Gileadites captured the fords of the Jordan against Ephraim. Whenever any of the fugitives of Ephraim said, "Let me cross over," the men of Gilead would say to him, "Are you an Ephraimite?" If he said, "No," 6 they told him, "Say 'Shibboleth,'"[c] and if he said "Sibboleth," unable to pronounce it correctly, they seized him and killed him at the Jordan crossing. At that time forty-two thousand[d] Ephraimites died.

7 Jephthah judged Israel six years. Then Jephthah the Gileadite died
and was buried in one of the cities of Gilead.[e]
8 After him Ibzan of Bethlehem[f] judged Israel. 9 He had thirty sons and
thirty daughters. He gave his daughters in marriage outside his clan
and brought in thirty daughters from outside for his sons. He judged
Israel seven years. 10 Then Ibzan died and was buried at Bethlehem.
11 After him Elon the Zebulunite judged Israel. He judged Israel ten
years. 12 Then Elon the Zebulunite died and was buried at Aijalon in
the land of Zebulun.
13 After him Abdon son of Hillel the Pirathonite judged Israel. 14 He had
forty sons and thirty grandsons, who rode on seventy donkeys. He
judged Israel eight years. 15 Then Abdon son of Hillel the Pirathonite
died and was buried at Pirathon in the land of Ephraim, in the hill
country of the Amalekites.

Notes

- a (12:1) Or "northward." Zaphon was a town in the Jordan Valley (Joshua 13:27).
- b (12:4) The meaning of the Ephraimites' taunt is uncertain. The Septuagint (B text) makes it the escaped Ephraimites who say, "You are of Gilead in the midst of Ephraim and in the midst of Manasseh."
- c (12:6) Hebrew shibboleth means "ear of grain" or "flowing stream." The Ephraimites' dialect evidently lacked the "sh" sound, so they said "sibboleth" with an "s." The Septuagint (B text) translates the word as "ear of grain" (Stachys); the A text translates it as "watchword."
- d (12:6) Or "forty-two units"; on the Hebrew word elef ("thousand," perhaps also "clan" or "military unit"), compare 20:2.
- e (12:7) So the Hebrew, "in the cities of Gilead." The Septuagint reads "in his city, in Gilead."
- f (12:8) Probably the Bethlehem in Zebulun (Joshua 19:15), not Bethlehem of Judah.

Chapter 13

1 The Israelites again did what was evil in the eyes of Yahweh, and
Yahweh gave them into the hand of the Philistines for forty years.
2 There was a man from Zorah, of the Danite clan, named Manoah.[a]
His wife was infertile and had no children. 3 The messenger of Yahweh
appeared to the woman and told her, "You have never been able to
bear a child, yet you will conceive and give birth to a son. 4 Now take
care that you drink no wine or other liquor, and avoid every unclean

food, 5 You will become pregnant and bear a son. A razor must never
touch his head, because the boy will be a Nazirite[b] consecrated to God
from birth, and he will begin delivering Israel from Philistine power."
6 Then the woman came and told her husband, saying, "A man of God
came to me, and his appearance was like the appearance of the angel
of God, very awesome. I did not ask him where he came from, and he
did not tell me his name, 7 yet he told me, 'You are going to conceive
and bear a son. Starting now, avoid wine and other liquor, and eat
nothing unclean, because the child will be a Nazirite, consecrated to
God from birth right up to the day of his death.'"
8 Then Manoah prayed to Yahweh and said, "O Lord, please let the
man of God whom you sent come to us again and teach us what we
should do for the boy who will be born." 9 God listened to the voice
of Manoah, and the angel of God came again to the woman as she
was sitting in the field. But Manoah her husband was not with her.
10 So the woman ran quickly and told her husband, saying to him,
"Look, the man who came to me the other day has appeared to me."
11 Manoah got up and went after his wife. He approached the man
and asked, "Are you the one who spoke with my wife?" "Yes," he said.
12 Manoah asked, "When your promise comes true, how should the
boy be raised, and what will he do?" 13 The angel of Yahweh said to
Manoah, "Of all that I said to the woman let her be careful. 14 She may
not eat anything that comes from the vine, neither let her drink wine
or strong drink, nor eat anything unclean. All that I commanded her
let her observe."
15 Manoah told Yahweh's messenger, "Let us hold you here while we
cook a young goat for you." 16 Yahweh's messenger told Manoah,
"Even if you urge me to stay, I won't touch your food. But should
you want to prepare a burnt offering, present it to Yahweh." (Manoah
did not realize he was speaking with Yahweh's messenger.) 17 Manoah
asked Yahweh's messenger, "What is your name, so we can honor
you when your word comes true?" 18 And the angel of Yahweh said
to him, "Why do you ask my name, seeing it is wonderful?"[c] 19 So
Manoah took the young goat with the grain offering and offered it on
the rock to Yahweh, and he[d] did a wonderful thing while Manoah and

his wife were watching. 20 As the flame rose from the altar toward the sky, Yahweh's messenger ascended in it. Manoah and his wife saw this and fell face down on the ground. 21 The angel of Yahweh did not appear again to Manoah and to his wife. Then Manoah knew that he was the angel of Yahweh. 22 Manoah told his wife, "We are certain to die, because we have seen God." 23 But his wife said to him, "If Yahweh had wanted to kill us, he would not have accepted a burnt offering and a grain offering from our hands, nor shown us all these things, nor now announced to us such things as these."
24 The woman bore a son and called his name Samson.[e] The boy grew, and Yahweh blessed him. 25 Yahweh's Spirit began to move him at Mahaneh-dan,[f] between Zorah and Eshtaol.

Notes

- a (13:2) Manoah means "rest."
- b (13:5) Nazirite means "one consecrated" or "separated" (see Numbers 6:1–21). The Septuagint (B text) keeps the Hebrew word (Nazir); the A text reads Naziraios, a form close to the wording of Matthew 2:23.
- c (13:18) Hebrew pil'i, "wonderful, beyond understanding"; compare Isaiah 9:6.
- d (13:19) Hebrew "and he did wonderfully," referring to the angel. The Septuagint (A text) reads "offered it to Yahweh, who does wonders."
- e (13:24) Samson (Hebrew Shimshon) is related to shemesh, "sun," perhaps meaning "little sun" or "of the sun." Beth-shemesh, "house of the sun," lay near Zorah.
- f (13:25) Mahaneh-dan means "camp of Dan" (compare 18:12).

Chapter 14

1 Samson went to Timnah, and in Timnah he noticed a young Philistine woman. 2 He returned and told his parents, "At Timnah I saw a Philistine woman. Get her for me as a wife." 3 His parents objected, "Can't you find a wife among your own relatives or in all our people? Must you take one from the pagan Philistines?" But Samson insisted to his father, "Get her for me! She is the one who pleases me." 4 His parents did not realize this was from Yahweh, who was looking for a pretext to confront the Philistines, since they were then Israel's rulers.
5 Samson and his parents went down to Timnah, and as they approached the vineyards there, a young lion suddenly came roaring at him. 6 Yahweh's Spirit seized him, and bare-handed he ripped the

lion apart as if it were a kid. But he said nothing to his parents about what he had done. 7 He went down and spoke with the woman, and Samson found her pleasing.
8 After some days he returned to take her, and he turned aside to see the carcass of the lion. And look, there was a swarm of bees in the body of the lion, and honey. 9 He scraped it out into his hands and went on, eating as he went. He came to his father and mother and gave some to them, and they ate. But he did not tell them that he had scraped the honey from the body of the lion.
10 His father visited the woman, and Samson held a banquet there, as young men customarily did. 11 When they saw him,[a] they brought thirty companions to be with him. 12 Samson told them, "Let me pose a riddle for you. If you solve it and give me the answer before the week-long feast ends, I will award you thirty linen shirts and thirty sets of fine clothing. 13 If you are unable to solve it, the thirty linen shirts and thirty sets of fine clothing will be mine." They answered, "Go ahead, tell us your riddle, and we will listen." 14 He said to them, "Out of the eater came something to eat, and out of the strong came something sweet." And for three days they could not solve the riddle.
15 On the seventh day[b] they said to Samson's wife, "Entice your husband to tell us the riddle, or we will burn you and your father's house with fire. Have you invited us here to impoverish us?" 16 Samson's wife sobbed against him and said, "All you feel for me is hatred! There is no love in you. You gave my countrymen a riddle and never told me the answer." He replied, "I haven't even told my own parents, so why would I tell you?" 17 She sobbed in front of him throughout the feast's seven days, and on day seven, because she badgered him so, he gave her the answer. She then explained the riddle to her countrymen. 18 And the men of the city said to him on the seventh day before the sun went down,[c] "What is sweeter than honey? What is stronger than a lion?" And he said to them, "If you had not plowed with my heifer, you would not have found out my riddle."
19 Then Yahweh's Spirit came powerfully over him. Down to Ashkelon he went, struck dead thirty of its men, stripped them, and handed their clothes to the guests who had solved the riddle. Furious, he

returned to his father's house. 20 And Samson's wife was given to his companion, who had been his best man.

Notes

- a (14:11) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint. With different vowels the Hebrew could be read "Because they feared him."
- b (14:15) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint and some other ancient versions read "the fourth day," which fits better with verses 14 and 17.
- c (14:18) Hebrew harsah, "toward the sun" (a rare word for the sun). Many scholars, with a change of one letter, read "before he went into the bridal chamber." The Septuagint (B text) reads "before sunrise."

Chapter 15

1 Some time later, around wheat harvest (in May–June),[a] Samson visited his wife, bringing a kid goat as a gift. "I am going to my wife's room," he said. But her father refused to admit him. 2 Her father explained, "I was convinced you despised her, so I gave her to the man who stood as your best man. Isn't her kid sister prettier? Have her instead." 3 Samson said to them, "This time I shall be blameless toward the Philistines when I do them harm." 4 So Samson went and caught three hundred foxes[b] and took torches. He turned them tail to tail and put a torch between each pair of tails. 5 He lit the torches and released the foxes into the Philistines' ripe grain, burning up the stacked sheaves and the standing crops, along with the vineyards and olive orchards. 6 Then the Philistines said, "Who has done this?" And they said, "Samson, the son-in-law of the Timnite, because he took his wife and gave her to his companion." And the Philistines came up and burned her and her father with fire. 7 Samson answered them, "Since you have behaved this way, I swear I will take revenge on you. Only then will I quit." 8 He attacked them savagely, slaughtering many,[c] then went down and took refuge in a rocky crevice at Etam.
9 Then the Philistines came up and camped in Judah and spread out at Lehi.[d] 10 And the men of Judah said, "Why have you come up against us?" They said, "We have come up to bind Samson, to do to him as he did to us." 11 Then three thousand men of Judah went down to the cleft of the rock of Etam and said to Samson, "Do you not know that the Philistines rule over us? What then is this that you have done

to us?" And he said to them, "As they did to me, so have I done to them." 12 They said, "We came down to bind you and deliver you into Philistine custody." Samson replied, "Promise me you will not kill me yourselves." 13 "No," they answered, "we only mean to tie you and give you to them. We swear we will not put you to death." They fastened him with two new cords and led him up from the rock.
14 As he arrived at Lehi, the Philistines rushed toward him shouting. Yahweh's Spirit came upon him with power, and the cords binding his arms turned to burnt flax and dropped from his wrists. 15 He found a fresh jawbone of a donkey, put out his hand, took it, and with it he struck down a thousand men. 16 And Samson said, "With the jawbone of a donkey, heaps upon heaps,[e] with the jawbone of a donkey I have struck down a thousand men." 17 When he had finished speaking, he threw away the jawbone from his hand. And that place was called Ramath-lehi.[f]
18 Burning with thirst, he cried out to Yahweh, "You granted this tremendous victory through your servant. Must I now perish from thirst and land in the hands of these pagans?" 19 God then split open a hollow in the earth at Lehi, and water gushed out. Samson drank, his strength came back, and he revived. That is why the spring is called En-hakkore,[g] and it remains at Lehi today. 20 And he judged Israel in the days of the Philistines twenty years.

Notes

- a (15:1) The wheat harvest followed the barley harvest and came in late spring, roughly the Hebrew month Sivan (Pentecost/Shavuot), in May–June.
- b (15:4) Or "jackals."
- c (15:8) Hebrew "leg upon thigh," an idiom for a crushing defeat.
- d (15:9) Lehi means "jawbone."
- e (15:16) Hebrew hamor homoratayim, a play on words: hamor means "donkey," and homer means "heap." The Septuagint reads "I have utterly destroyed them."
- f (15:17) Ramath-lehi means "height of the jawbone." The Septuagint (B text) understands it as "the lifting (or throwing away) of the jawbone."
- g (15:19) En-hakkore means "spring of the one who called." The Septuagint (B text) reads "Well of the invoker."

Chapter 16

1 Samson visited Gaza, where he noticed a prostitute and went in to
spend the night with her. 2 The people of Gaza heard, "Samson is
here!" They encircled the town and waited in ambush at the city gate
all night, staying quiet and thinking, "At first light we will kill him."
3 But Samson stayed in bed only till midnight. Then he rose, grabbed
the town gate's double doors with both posts, tore them loose along
with the bar, hoisted them onto his shoulders, and hauled them up to
the summit of the hill facing Hebron.
4 After this he loved a woman in the Valley of Sorek,[a] whose name
was Delilah.[b] 5 The Philistine rulers approached her and said, "Coax
him. Find the secret of his tremendous strength and how we can
overpower him and tie him up to subdue him. Each of us will pay you
eleven hundred silver coins."[c] 6 Delilah asked Samson, "Tell me, what
is the secret of your great strength, and how could you be tied up and
subdued?" 7 Samson told her, "If anyone binds me with seven fresh
bowstrings,[d] still damp and unused, I will lose my strength and be like
everyone else." 8 Then the lords of the Philistines brought up to her
seven fresh bowstrings that had not been dried, and she bound him
with them. 9 She had men waiting in ambush in the next room. She
shouted, "Samson, the Philistines are on you!" But he snapped the
strings like a flax thread that singes in a flame. His secret remained
undiscovered.
10 Delilah accused Samson, "You made a fool of me and lied to me. Now
tell me honestly how you can be tied up." 11 He told her, "If anyone
ties me firmly with new ropes that have never been used, I will lose
my strength and be like everyone else." 12 Delilah took fresh ropes and
bound him, then screamed, "Samson, the Philistines are on you!" The
ambushers lay waiting in the next room. But he snapped the ropes
off his arms like so much thread.
13 Delilah complained to Samson, "So far you have mocked me and
lied. Say how someone might tie you up." He said, "Weave the seven
braids of my hair into the loom's fabric."[e] 14 She secured it with the
pin and shouted, "Samson, the Philistines are on you!" He woke up
and yanked out the pin, the loom, and the fabric.

15 Then she said, “How can you claim to love me when your heart is
elsewhere? Three times now you have made fun of me, and you still
have not revealed what makes you so strong.” 16 Day after day she
nagged him with her pleading until he felt sick enough to die. 17 So he
opened his whole heart to her: “A blade has never been used on my
head, since I have been set apart for God as a Nazirite from the day
of my birth. Shave my head and my strength will drain away; I will
turn weak and become like any ordinary man.”
18 Delilah saw that he had finally told her everything, so she sent word
summoning the Philistine rulers: “Come one more time; he has con-
fided in me completely.” The rulers came to her, carrying the silver.
19 She made him sleep on her knees. And she called a man and had
him shave off the seven locks of his head. Then she began to humble[f]
him, and his strength left him. 20 She shouted, “Samson, the Philistines
are on you!” Waking from his sleep, he thought, “I will break free as
before, with a shake.” He had no idea that Yahweh had abandoned
him. 21 And the Philistines seized him and gouged out his eyes and
brought him down to Gaza and bound him with bronze shackles. And
he ground grain in the prison. 22 But the hair of his head began to
grow again after it had been shaved.
23 The Philistine rulers assembled for a great sacrificial feast to their
god Dagon[g] and for rejoicing, saying, “Our god has put Samson, our
enemy, in our hands.” 24 When the crowd saw him, they praised their
god: “Our god has put into our power the foe who ravaged our land
and killed so many of us!” 25 When their hearts were merry, they said,
“Call Samson, so that he may entertain us.” So they called Samson
out of the prison, and he entertained them. They made him stand
between the pillars. 26 Samson said to the boy leading him, “Place my
hands on the pillars that support the building, so I can lean on them.”
27 The building was crowded, full of men and women. Every Philistine
ruler was present, and some three thousand more were up on the
roof, watching Samson perform.
28 Samson prayed to Yahweh: “Lord Yahweh, remember me! Give
me strength just this one time, God, so that with a single blow I
may repay the Philistines for my two eyes.” 29 Samson felt for the

two central columns that supported the building. He braced himself against them, one under his right hand and the other under his left. 30 And Samson said, “Let me die with the Philistines!” Then he bent with all his might, and the house fell upon the lords and upon all the people who were in it. So the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those whom he had killed during his life. 31 His brothers and his father’s whole house came down, collected him, carried him back, and buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol in the burial place of his father Manoah. For twenty years he had been Israel’s judge.

Notes

- a (16:4) Sorek means “choice vine.” The Septuagint (B text) keeps the Hebrew as a name (Alsorech); the A text reads “the brook of Sorek.”
- b (16:4) The meaning of Delilah is uncertain; it may be related to dallah, “hair, threads,” or to dalal, “to be weak, small.”
- c (16:5) Probably shekels; 1,100 shekels weighed about 28 pounds (12.6 kilograms, kg). Hebrew “a thousand and a hundred of silver.”
- d (16:7) Or “cords” or “sinews”; Hebrew yetarim, used of bowstrings and tent cords.
- e (16:13) The Hebrew here appears to be shorter, perhaps because a scribe’s eye skipped between similar words. The Septuagint has a longer text: “If you weave the seven locks of my head with the web and fasten them with the pin into the wall, then I shall become weak and be like any other man.” And in verse 14: “And while he slept, Delilah took the seven locks of his head and wove them into the web.”
- f (16:19) Or “to afflict” or “to subdue.” The Septuagint reads “and she began to humble him”; some scholars read “he began to grow weak.”
- g (16:23) Dagon was a grain or storm god worshiped in Mesopotamia, Syria, and Philistia.

Chapter 17

1 There was a man of the hill country of Ephraim whose name was Micah.[a] 2 He said to his mother, “The eleven hundred pieces of silver[b] that were taken from you, about which you uttered a curse and also spoke it in my hearing—look, the silver is with me; I took it.” And his mother said, “Blessed be my son by Yahweh.” 3 He returned the eleven hundred pieces of silver to his mother. And his mother said, “I solemnly dedicate the silver to Yahweh from my hand for my son, to make a carved image and a cast image. So now I will return it to you.” 4 When he gave the silver back to her, she took two hundred shekels of it to a silversmith, who fashioned a carved idol and a molten one.

These stood in Micah's house. 5 This Micah owned a shrine.[c] He had
an ephod made, and household idols,[d] and appointed[e] one of his own
sons to be his priest. 6 In those days there was no king in Israel.
Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.
7 There was a young Levite from Bethlehem in Judah, belonging
to the Judah clan, who was staying there as a resident foreigner. 8
He left Bethlehem in Judah to live wherever he could find lodging.
On his way he reached Micah's house in Ephraim's hill country. 9
Micah asked him, "Where are you from?" He said, "I am a Levite of
Bethlehem in Judah, looking for a place to stay." 10 Micah said to him,
"Stay with me, and be to me a father and a priest, and I will give you
ten pieces of silver[f] a year and a set of clothes and your food." So the
Levite went in. 11 The Levite agreed to live with Micah, and the young
man became like a son to him. 12 Micah ordained the Levite, and the
young man became his priest, and he was in the house of Micah. 13
Micah concluded, "Now I am certain that Yahweh will do me good,
since a Levite is my priest."

Notes

- a (17:1) Micah (here Hebrew Mikayehu, verses 1 and 4; elsewhere Mikah) means "Who is like Yahweh?"
- b (17:2) Probably shekels; 1,100 shekels weighed about 28 pounds (12.6 kilograms, kg). Verse 4's two hundred pieces weighed about 5 pounds (2.3 kg).
- c (17:5) Hebrew "a house of God" (or "of gods").
- d (17:5) Hebrew teraphim, small household idols, perhaps also used in divination.
- e (17:5) Hebrew "filled the hand of," an idiom for installing a priest; also in verse 12.
- f (17:10) Probably shekels; ten shekels weighed about 4 ounces (115 grams, g).

Chapter 18

1 At that time Israel had no king. And at that time the Danite clan
was still seeking a place to settle, because it had not yet received
an allotment among Israel's tribes. 2 From their clans, from Zorah
and Eshtaol, the Danites picked five capable men to scout and map
the land. Their instructions: "Go, survey the country." They reached
Ephraim's hill country, arrived at Micah's house, and spent the night.
3 Near Micah's house, the young Levite's accent gave him away to
them. They stopped and asked him, "Who brought you here? What is

your business in this place? What is your stake here?" 4 He explained,
"Micah made an arrangement with me. He pays me, and I serve as his
priest." 5 They said, "Ask God, so we can learn whether our mission
will succeed." 6 The priest told them, "Go in peace. Yahweh is watching
over the mission you are on."
7 The five men left and reached Laish. They watched the people
living there: they were secure, like the Sidonians, calm and trusting,
wanting nothing the earth could supply, and prosperous.[a] They lived
far from Sidon, with no ties to anyone.[b] 8 When the five returned
to their kinsmen at Zorah and Eshtaol, the kinsmen asked, "What
did you find out?" 9 They answered, "Let's march against them! We
saw that land, and it is excellent. Why are you sitting still? Don't
hesitate; go and capture the country. 10 When you arrive, you will find
a trusting people and a wide-open country. God has delivered it to
you, a place that lacks nothing the earth can provide."
11 So six hundred men of the clan of the Danites, armed with weapons
of war, set out from Zorah and Eshtaol, 12 They went up and pitched
camp at Kiriath-jearim in Judah. For that reason the spot has been
named Mahaneh-dan[c] ever since; it lies west[d] of Kiriath-jearim. 13 And
they passed on from there to the hill country of Ephraim and came
to the house of Micah.
14 The five men who had scouted the Laish region said to their
kinsmen, "Did you know that one of these houses holds an ephod,
household idols, a carved image, and a cast idol? Think about what
to do." 15 And they turned aside there and came to the house of the
young Levite, at the house of Micah, and asked him about his welfare.
16 The six hundred Danite men, equipped for battle, stood beside the
entrance to the gateway. 17 The five men who had scouted the land
went inside and removed the carved idol, the ephod, the household
gods, and the molten idol. Meanwhile the priest was standing by the
gateway's entrance with the six hundred armed warriors. 18 When
these went into Micah's house and took the carved image, the ephod,
the household gods, and the cast image, the priest said to them, "What
are you doing?" 19 They told him, "Silence! Cover your mouth with
your hand, and come along as our father and priest. Would you rather

serve one man's household as priest, or serve a whole tribe and clan of Israel?" 20 The priest was delighted. He took the ephod, the idols, and the carved image and joined the Danite company. 21 Then they turned and left, placing the children, the livestock, and the baggage ahead of them.
22 They were some distance from Micah's house when the men living in the neighborhood were rallied, and they caught up with the Danites. 23 Calling out to the Danites, who looked back at them, they asked Micah, "What is wrong? Why have you brought such a crowd?" 24 He replied, "You carry off the gods I made, along with my priest, and leave. What do I have left? And you ask me, 'What's wrong?'" 25 The Danites warned him, "Keep your voice down around us, or some hot-tempered men may attack you, and you and your family will lose your lives." 26 Then the Danites went their way. And when Micah saw that they were too strong for him, he turned and went back to his home.
27 They carried off Micah's handiwork and his priest, and reached Laish, a calm and unsuspecting people. They slaughtered them with swords and burned the town to the ground. 28 No one came to rescue the city, because it lay a long way from Sidon and had no dealings with outsiders. It was situated in the valley by Beth-rehob. The Danites reconstructed the city and made it their home. 29 They renamed the town Dan after their ancestor Dan, Israel's son; its earlier name had been Laish. 30 And the Danites set up the carved image for themselves, and Jonathan son of Gershom, son of Moses,[e] he and his sons were priests to the tribe of the Danites until the day of the captivity of the land.[f] 31 They kept Micah's carved image for themselves all the time God's house stood at Shiloh.

Notes

- a (18:7) The meaning of the Hebrew of this clause is uncertain.
- b (18:7) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint (B text). The A text, followed by some scholars, reads "with Aram" (Syria), a difference of one letter in Hebrew (adam, "anyone," and aram).
- c (18:12) Mahaneh-dan means "camp of Dan."
- d (18:12) Hebrew "behind," that is, west.
- e (18:30) Most manuscripts of the Hebrew text read "Manasseh," but the letter n (nun) is written above the line, raised or "suspended" between the other letters,

the only suspended nun in the Hebrew Bible. Without it the word reads "Moses." Jewish tradition (Talmud, Bava Batra 109b) explains that the scribes added the nun to spare Moses the shame of a grandson who served as an idolatrous priest, while marking it as an addition. The Septuagint A text and the Latin Vulgate read "Moses"; the B text reads "Manasseh." Gershom was the son of Moses (Exodus 2:22).

- f (18:30) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint. Some scholars, with a slight change of the Hebrew, read "the captivity of the ark" (compare 1 Samuel 4:11, 21–22). The captivity of the land may refer to the Assyrian deportations in 734–732 B.C. or 722 B.C.

Chapter 19

1 In those days Israel had no king. A certain Levite was living in
a remote corner of Ephraim's hill country, and from Bethlehem in
Judah he took a concubine. 2 His concubine became angry with him[a]
and left, going back to her father's home in Bethlehem in Judah. She
remained there four months. 3 Her husband set out to follow her and
win her over, so she would return. He took along his servant and
two donkeys. She brought him into her father's home, and when the
young woman's father spotted him, he welcomed him gladly. 4 His
father-in-law, the young woman's father, persuaded him to stay, and
he lodged with them for three days, eating, drinking, and sleeping
there. 5 On the fourth morning they got up early and he was ready
to leave, but the girl's father urged his son-in-law, "Refresh yourself
with a bite to eat, then you can go." 6 The two men sat down together
to eat and drink. Then the young woman's father urged the man,
"Won't you agree to stay the night and enjoy yourself?" 7 When the
man stood to leave, his father-in-law pressed him, and he stayed
another night. 8 On the fifth day he rose at dawn to leave. But the
young woman's father urged him, "Eat something first and wait until
the afternoon." So the two of them dined together. 9 When the man,
his concubine, and his servant stood to go, his wife's father, the young
woman's father, told him, "Look, evening is coming on and the day is
nearly gone. Stay one more night. See, the sun is setting. Spend the
night here and enjoy yourself. You can get up early tomorrow, begin
your trip, and head home."
10 But the man refused to stay another night. He rose and left, and
reached a point across from Jebus (that is, Jerusalem). His two saddled

donkeys were with him, along with his concubine. 11 By the time
they were close to Jebus, the day was nearly gone, and the servant
suggested to his master, “Let’s turn off to this Jebusite town and stay
the night there.” 12 His master answered, “We won’t detour into a
foreign city whose inhabitants are not Israelites. We will continue to
Gibeah.” 13 He told his servant, “Let’s try to reach one of these towns
and stay the night in Gibeah or Ramah.” 14 So they passed on and
went their way. And the sun went down on them near Gibeah, which
belongs to Benjamin, 15 and they stopped there to spend the night in
Gibeah. He went in and took a seat in the town’s public square, but
nobody offered them a home for the night.
16 Then an old man came along from his work in the fields that
evening. He was originally from Ephraim’s hill country and was
living in Gibeah, though the townspeople were Benjaminites. 17 The
old man looked up and noticed the traveler in the town square.
“Where are you headed?” he asked. “Where did you come from?” 18
He answered, “We are traveling from Bethlehem in Judah toward a
remote corner of Ephraim’s hill country, which is my home. I had
gone to Bethlehem in Judah, and now I am heading to the house of
Yahweh,[b] but nobody has invited me into a home. 19 We carry our own
straw and feed for the donkeys, plus bread and wine for me, for your
servant woman, and for the young man traveling with us. We need
nothing else.” 20 The old man replied, “You are welcome. Whatever
you require, I will provide. Just don’t sleep out in the open square.” 21
He led them to his house and fed the donkeys. The travelers bathed
their feet, then ate and drank.
22 While they were enjoying themselves, a gang of the town’s
scoundrels[c] ringed the house and hammered on its door. They
shouted to the elderly owner, “Send out the man who has come to
your house, so that we can have sex with him.” 23 The owner of the
house stepped outside and pleaded with them, “No, my friends, please
don’t do such a wicked thing. This man is my guest; don’t commit this
outrage. 24 Here are my daughter, a virgin, and his concubine. Let me
send them out. Abuse them and treat them however you like, but do
not commit such an atrocity against this man.” 25 The men refused to

heed him. So the man grabbed his concubine and shoved her outside to them. They raped her and tortured her throughout the night until morning, and at first light released her. 26 And as morning appeared, the woman came and fell down at the door of the man's house where her master was, until it was light.

27 When her master rose that morning and opened the house door to continue his journey, there lay his concubine at the entrance, her hands stretched out on the threshold. 28 "Get up," he told her, "we are leaving." She did not respond.[d] He loaded her on the donkey and started for home. 29 Once inside his house, he picked up a knife, took hold of his concubine, cut her body apart into twelve parts, and sent them to every part of Israel. 30 Everyone who saw it said, "Never has such a deed been done or witnessed since the day Israel left Egypt. Think about it, discuss it, and speak up!"

Notes

- a (19:2) Hebrew "played the harlot against him" (zanah). Some Greek manuscripts read "was angry with him," perhaps reflecting a different Hebrew verb; the Septuagint (B text) reads "departed from him."
- b (19:18) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint reads "to my house," which fits verse 29; the Hebrew may have arisen from a misread abbreviation.
- c (19:22) Hebrew beliya'al, "worthlessness."
- d (19:28) The Septuagint adds "for she was dead."

Chapter 20

1 All Israel, from Dan down to Beersheba and from Gilead too, marched out, and the community gathered as one person before Yahweh at Mizpah. 2 The leaders of every tribe of Israel took their positions in the gathering of God's people: four hundred thousand[a] infantrymen carrying swords. 3 (The Benjaminites heard that the Israelites had gone to Mizpah.) The Israelites demanded, "Explain how this wicked deed came about." 4 And the Levite, the husband of the woman who was murdered, answered and said, "I came to Gibeah that belongs to Benjamin, I and my concubine, to spend the night. 5 During the night the lords of Gibeah attacked me, surrounding the house. They intended to murder me, and they raped my concubine so savagely that she died. 6 I took my concubine, cut her into pieces,

and sent them across Israel's whole territory, because they have done
a vile and shameful thing in Israel. 7 Look, you Israelites, all of you,
give your advice and counsel here."
8 The entire people rose together and swore, "None of us will return
to his tent or go back to his home. 9 But now this is what we will do
to Gibeah: we will go up against it by lot, 10 We will pick one man in
ten from all Israel's tribes, one in a hundred, and one in a thousand,
to gather food for the army. Then, once the troops arrive, they will
punish Gibeah in Benjamin for the disgraceful crime it committed in
Israel." 11 So the men of Israel assembled against the town, united as a
single body.
12 The tribes of Israel sent envoys to every clan of Benjamin with this
question: "What is this crime committed among you? 13 Surrender
those scoundrels in Gibeah, so that we may execute them and cleanse
Israel of this evil." But the Benjaminites refused to obey their fellow
Israelites. 14 Then the Benjaminites came together out of the cities
to Gibeah to go out to battle against the Israelites. 15 On that day
the Benjaminites recruited from their towns twenty-six thousand[b]
swordsmen, in addition to seven hundred elite troops from Gibeah's
population. 16 Among all these troops were seven hundred select men
who were left-handed;[c] each could sling a stone at a hair's width and
never miss. 17 The men of Israel, not counting Benjamin, numbered
four hundred thousand sword-bearers, every one a seasoned warrior.
18 The Israelites set out for Bethel and asked God, "Which of us should
march first against the Benjaminites?" Yahweh answered, "Judah
goes first."
19 Then the Israelites rose in the morning and camped against Gibeah.
20 The men of Israel marched against Benjamin and took positions
opposite them at Gibeah. 21 The Benjaminites came out of Gibeah and
destroyed on that day twenty-two thousand men of the Israelites. 22
But the Israelite soldiers rallied their courage and again assembled in
the same location they had occupied the day before. 23 The Israelites
went and wept in Yahweh's presence until evening, and they asked
Yahweh, "Should we once more march out to battle against our
kinsmen the Benjaminites?" Yahweh said, "March against them."

24 So the Israelites came near against the Benjaminites the second
day. 25 And Benjamin went against them out of Gibeah the second
day, and destroyed eighteen thousand men of the Israelites. All these
were men who drew the sword. 26 Then all the Israelites, the whole
army, went up and came to Bethel and wept. They sat there before
Yahweh and fasted that day until evening, and offered burnt offerings
and peace offerings before Yahweh. 27 And the Israelites inquired of
Yahweh (for the ark of the covenant of God was there in those days,
28 Phinehas, Eleazar's son and Aaron's grandson, served before it in
those years). The Israelites asked, "Should we go out to battle against
our kinsmen the Benjaminites once more, or give up?" Yahweh
replied, "Attack! Tomorrow I will hand them over to you."
29 So Israel set men in ambush around Gibeah. 30 On the third day
the Israelites again marched against the Benjaminites and took up
positions facing Gibeah, as they had done before. 31 The Benjaminites
advanced against Israel's army and were lured away from the town.
Just as earlier, they began wounding and killing Israelites along the
roads, one leading to Bethel, another toward Gibeah, and in the fields,
about thirty Israelites in all. 32 And the Benjaminites said, "They are
defeated before us, as at the first." But the Israelites said, "Let us flee
and draw them away from the city to the highways." 33 All Israel's
men left their positions and formed their line at Baal-tamar,[d] while
the ambush force burst from its cover west of Geba.[e] 34 Ten thousand
picked soldiers from throughout Israel advanced on Gibeah, and the
fighting was fierce. The Benjaminites had no idea that catastrophe
was approaching. 35 Yahweh gave Israel victory over Benjamin, and
on that day Israel killed 25,100 Benjaminite swordsmen.
36 The Benjaminites realized they were losing. Israel's soldiers had
retreated before them, counting on the troops they had hidden near
Gibeah. 37 The ambushers raced into Gibeah, spread out, and put the
entire town to the sword. 38 The agreed signal between the Israelite
army and the hidden troops was a tall column of smoke rising
from the town 39 was the cue for Israel's troops to turn and fight.
Benjamin had started to wound and kill some thirty Israelites. They
told themselves, "We are beating them just as in the first battle!" 40

But when the column of smoke started to climb from the town, the Benjaminites looked back, and the whole town was rising in flames to the sky. 41 Then the men of Israel turned, and the men of Benjamin were dismayed, for they saw that disaster was close upon them. 42 They turned away from the Israelites toward the desert, but the battle caught up with them, and men from the towns cut them down in the middle of the fight. 43 They encircled the Benjaminites, chased them down, and trampled them from Nohah[f] to a point east of Gibeah. 44 Eighteen thousand men of Benjamin fell; all of them were men of valor. 45 The survivors turned and ran for the desert, to the rock of Rimmon. Along the roads five thousand of them were cut down,[g] and the pursuit pressed on as far as Gidom, where two thousand more fell. 46 So all who fell that day of Benjamin were twenty-five thousand men who drew the sword, all of them men of valor. 47 But six hundred men turned and ran into the wilderness to Rimmon's rock, where they stayed for four months. 48 The Israelites then went back and attacked the rest of Benjamin, killing the inhabitants of every town, human and animal, everything they came across. They also burned every town they reached.

Notes

- a (20:2) The Hebrew word elef, "thousand," may in some contexts denote a clan or military unit rather than an exact count; the numbers are given here as written. So throughout this chapter.
- b (20:15) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint (B text) reads "twenty-three thousand"; compare verses 35 and 46.
- c (20:16) Hebrew "bound in the right hand," as in 3:15. The Septuagint reads "able to use both hands alike."
- d (20:33) Baal-tamar means "lord of the palm tree."
- e (20:33) Maareh-geba probably means "the open area of Geba (or Gibeah)"; the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint keeps it as a name.
- f (20:43) Or "from their resting place"; Hebrew menuhah. The Septuagint reads "from Nua."
- g (20:45) Hebrew "gleaned," that is, picked off like gleanings.

Chapter 21

1 At Mizpah the Israelites had taken an oath: "None of us will marry his daughter to a Benjaminite." 2 The people came to Bethel and sat

in God's presence until evening, crying aloud in bitter grief. 3 They
asked, "Why, Yahweh, God of Israel, has this befallen Israel, so that
one of our tribes is missing today?" 4 Early the next day the people got
up, built an altar there, and presented burnt offerings and fellowship
offerings. 5 The Israelites asked, "Is there any tribe of Israel that did
not join the gathering before Yahweh?" They had taken a binding
oath that whoever failed to appear before Yahweh at Mizpah must
be put to death. 6 The Israelites felt sorry for their kinsmen the
Benjaminites and said, "Today one tribe has been cut off from Israel.
7 What shall we do for wives for those who are left, since we have
sworn by Yahweh that we will not give them any of our daughters
for wives?"
8 They asked, "Which of Israel's tribes failed to come to Yahweh
at Mizpah?" They discovered that nobody from Jabesh-gilead had
joined the gathering in the camp. 9 For when the people were mus-
tered, look, not one of the inhabitants of Jabesh-gilead was there. 10
So the assembly sent twelve thousand of its best soldiers with this
command: "Go and kill the people of Jabesh-gilead by the sword,
women and children included. 11 Here is what you must do: put to
death every man, and every woman who has had intercourse with a
man."[a] 12 And they found among the inhabitants of Jabesh-gilead four
hundred young virgins who had not known a man by lying with him,
and they brought them to the camp at Shiloh, which is in the land
of Canaan.
13 Then the whole congregation sent word to the Benjaminites who
were at the rock of Rimmon and proclaimed peace to them. 14 At that
point Benjamin returned, and the survivors were given the Jabesh-
gilead women who had been left alive. Even so, the women did
not suffice.[b] 15 And the people had compassion on Benjamin because
Yahweh had made a breach in the tribes of Israel.
16 Then the elders of the congregation said, "What shall we do for
wives for those who are left, since the women are destroyed out of
Benjamin?" 17 And they said, "There must be an inheritance for the
survivors of Benjamin, so that a tribe not be blotted out from Israel. 18
Yet we cannot give them wives from our daughters." For the Israelites

had sworn, “Cursed be he who gives a wife to Benjamin.” 19 Then they remembered, “Yahweh’s annual festival is being held at Shiloh,[c] which is north of Bethel, east of the road from Bethel to Shechem, and south of Lebonah.” 20 And they commanded the Benjaminites, saying, “Go and lie in ambush in the vineyards 21 and keep watch. When Shiloh’s young women come out to join the dancing, run from the vineyards, grab a wife each from among them, and head for Benjamin’s territory. 22 If their fathers or brothers come to us with complaints, we will tell them, ‘Be generous and let us keep them, since we did not capture a wife for each of them in the war, and you did not give them away yourselves, or you would now be guilty.’”[d] 23 The Benjaminites did that. They carried off as many wives as they needed from the dancing women. Then they went home to their own land, rebuilt their towns, and settled in them. 24 The Israelites dispersed from that place, each man to his own tribe and clan, each to his own allotted land. 25 In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

Notes

- a (21:11) The Septuagint adds “but the virgins you shall save alive. And they did so.”
- b (21:14) Hebrew “but they did not find enough for them.” The Septuagint reads “and it pleased them so.”
- c (21:19) Probably the autumn Festival of Booths (Tabernacles), held at the end of the grape harvest in the seventh month (in September–October); compare the vineyards in verses 20–21. This identification is not certain.
- d (21:22) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. The Greek manuscripts differ in this verse.

Ruth

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 During the era when judges governed Israel, famine struck, and a
man from Bethlehem[a] in Judah left with his wife and both sons, to
reside as foreigners in Moabite territory. 2 The man's name was Elim-
elech,[b] his wife's was Naomi,[c] and his two sons were called Mahlon[d]
and Chilion.[e] The family belonged to Ephrath, near Bethlehem in
Judah. Having reached Moabite territory, they settled there. 3 Then
Elimelech, Naomi's husband, died, leaving her alone with her two
sons. 4 Both sons married Moabite women. The first wife's name was
Orpah,[f] the second's was Ruth.[g] After they had lived there some ten
years, 5 Then Mahlon and Chilion both died as well, and the woman
was left bereft, without her two boys or her husband.
6 Naomi prepared to leave Moab with her two daughters-in-law and
head home, because word had reached her in Moab that Yahweh had
turned his attention to his people and supplied them with bread.[h] 7
So she departed the place of her stay, accompanied by her two sons'
wives, and the three took the road back toward the land of Judah. 8
Naomi urged each of her daughters-in-law, "Go on back, both of you,
to your own mothers' homes. May Yahweh show faithful love[i] to you,
just as you showed it to the departed and to me. 9 May Yahweh let each
of you find peace in a new husband's household!" She kissed them
goodbye, but they began sobbing aloud. 10 They protested, "No, we
are returning with you, to your people." 11 Naomi replied, "Go home,
my girls. Why come along with me? Am I still carrying sons in my
body who could become your husbands? 12 Go home, my girls, and be
on your way. I am too old to take a husband. Even supposing I had
hope, and were married tonight, and gave birth to sons, 13 would you
hold off until they were grown? Would you stay unmarried for their
sake? Certainly not, my girls! My lot is far more bitter than yours,

because Yahweh's own hand has struck me down." 14 Then they lifted up their voices and wept again. And Orpah kissed her mother-in-law, but Ruth clung to her.

15 Naomi said, "See, your brother's widow has gone home to her people and her gods. Follow her back." 16 Ruth replied, "Do not press me to abandon you or to turn back from going with you. Wherever you travel, I will travel, and wherever you stay overnight, so will I. Your people will be mine, and your God will be my God. 17 Where you die, I die, and I will be laid in the ground beside you. May Yahweh punish me severely if anything other than death separates you and me." 18 Seeing how firmly Ruth had resolved to accompany her, Naomi stopped arguing.

19 The two of them traveled on until they arrived in Bethlehem. Their arrival set the entire town buzzing, and the local women exclaimed, "Can this really be Naomi?" 20 She told them, "Don't call me Naomi. Call me Mara,[j] because Shaddai[k] has embittered my life terribly. 21 I left here with plenty, but Yahweh has returned me with nothing. Why call me Naomi, now that Yahweh has stood as a witness against me[l] and Shaddai has sent disaster on me?"

22 That is how Naomi came back, along with Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law, who had come with her out of Moab. They reached Bethlehem just as the barley harvest was starting (in March–April).[m]

Notes

- a (1:1) Bethlehem means "house of bread."
- b (1:2) Elimelech means "my God is king."
- c (1:2) Naomi means "pleasant" or "my pleasantness."
- d (1:2) The meaning of Mahlon is uncertain; it is often explained as "sickly" or "weakness."
- e (1:2) Chilion probably means "failing," "finished," or "consumption."
- f (1:4) The meaning of Orpah is uncertain; it is often connected with ʿoref, "back of the neck," as one who turned back (verse 14).
- g (1:4) The meaning of Ruth is uncertain; it is often explained as "friend" or "companion," or as "refreshment."
- h (1:6) Hebrew lehem, "bread," echoing the name Bethlehem.
- i (1:8) Hebrew hesed, "steadfast love, loyal kindness," a key word in Ruth (2:20; 3:10).
- j (1:20) Mara means "bitter."

- k (1:20) A divine name, traditionally translated “the Almighty”; its original meaning is uncertain. Also in verse 21. The Septuagint reads “the Mighty One.”
- l (1:21) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint and some other ancient versions read “has humbled me,” from the same Hebrew letters with different vowels.
- m (1:22) The barley harvest began around Passover in the first month of the spring-start calendar, Nisan (in March–April), and lasted about seven weeks until the wheat harvest ended at Pentecost/Shavuot (2:23). Today barley in this region is reaped mainly in April.

Chapter 2

1 Naomi had a kinsman through her husband, a man of standing[a] from
Elimelech’s family, named Boaz.[b] 2 Ruth the Moabite said to Naomi,
“Allow me to go out into the fields and pick up leftover grain behind
anyone who is kind enough to permit it.” Naomi answered, “Go
ahead, my daughter.” 3 Off she went, and into a field, where she began
collecting grain behind the harvesters. As it happened, the plot she
chose belonged to Boaz, a member of Elimelech’s clan. 4 And look,
Boaz came from Bethlehem. And he said to the reapers, “Yahweh be
with you!” And they answered, “Yahweh bless you.” 5 Boaz asked the
servant in charge of the harvesters, “Who is that young woman with
you?” 6 The foreman answered, “She is a Moabite girl who came back
along with Naomi from Moab. 7 She asked, ‘May I please follow the
harvesters and collect fallen heads of grain among the bundles?’ She
came, and from first thing this morning until just now she has stayed
at it, pausing only briefly in the hut.”[c]
8 Boaz then spoke to Ruth: “Listen to me, my daughter. Don’t go
off to gather in someone else’s field, and don’t move on from here.
Stay right beside the young women who work for me. 9 Keep watch
on the field where the men are cutting grain, and trail behind the
women. I have ordered the young men to leave you alone. Whenever
you are thirsty, walk over to the water jars and drink what the men
have drawn.” 10 Ruth dropped with her face to the ground, bowing
low, and asked him, “Why are you so generous, noticing me, when
I am a foreigner?”[d] 11 Boaz answered, “Everything you have done for
your husband’s mother since your husband died has been reported
to me in full: how you abandoned your own father, your mother, and

your homeland, to settle among a nation you had never known. 12 May
Yahweh pay you back for your deeds, and may you receive full wages
from Yahweh, the God of Israel, beneath whose wings[e] you have come
for shelter." 13 She responded, "May I always find such approval from
you, sir. You have reassured me and spoken tenderly to your servant,
though I do not even rank with your hired women."
14 At mealtime Boaz invited her, "Join us here, help yourself to the
bread, and dip a piece into the sour wine." Ruth took her place next to
the harvesters, and he passed her roasted kernels. She ate her fill and
still had food left over. 15 When she got up to resume gathering, Boaz
ordered his workers, "Even let her pick among the bundled stalks,
and don't embarrass her. 16 Even pull a few stalks out of the bundles
and drop them for her to pick up. Don't scold her." 17 So she gleaned in
the field until evening. Then she beat out what she had gleaned, and
it was about three-fifths of a bushel[f] of barley. 18 She lifted up what she
had gathered and went back into town. Her husband's mother saw
how much she had collected. Ruth also took out the leftovers from
her meal and handed them to Naomi. 19 Her mother-in-law asked,
"Where did you gather grain today? Where were you working? A
blessing on whoever noticed you!" Ruth described to her mother-in-
law whose field she had worked in, and said, "The man I worked
for today is named Boaz." 20 Naomi said to her daughter-in-law, "May
Yahweh bless him, for his loyal love has not left the living or the
dead!" Then Naomi added, "That man is one of our close kinsmen,
among those with the duty to redeem for our family."[g] 21 Ruth the
Moabite continued, "He also told me, 'Stay with my workers until
they have brought in my whole harvest.'" 22 Naomi told her daughter-
in-law Ruth, "It is wise, my daughter, for you to work with his young
women, so that no one harms you in a different field." 23 So she stayed
close to Boaz's young women, gathering grain until both the barley
and the wheat harvests were over (in May–June).[h] And she kept living
with her mother-in-law.

Notes

- a (2:1) Or "a man of standing" or "a man of wealth"; Hebrew gibbor hayil. Compare "a worthy woman" ('eshet hayil) in 3:11.

- b (2:1) The meaning of Boaz is uncertain; it is often explained as “in him is strength” or “quickness.” Boaz was also the name of one of the two bronze pillars of Solomon’s temple (1 Kings 7:21).
- c (2:7) The meaning of the Hebrew of the last part of this verse is uncertain. The Septuagint reads “and she stood from morning until evening and has not rested in the field even a little.”
- d (2:10) The Hebrew contains a pun: the verb “take notice” (hikkir) sounds like the word “foreigner” (nokriyyah).
- e (2:12) Hebrew kanaf, “wing,” also “edge of a garment”; compare 3:9.
- f (2:17) Hebrew “about an ephah”; an ephah was about 22 liters (L). That much threshed barley would weigh roughly 30 pounds (13–14 kilograms, kg), a remarkably large amount for one day’s gleaning.
- g (2:20) Hebrew go’el (plural go’alim), the close relative who had the duty to buy back family land, to redeem a relative sold into slavery, to avenge a relative’s death, and, in Ruth, to provide an heir for the dead (Leviticus 25:25–55; Numbers 35:19; Deuteronomy 25:5–10). Also in 3:9, 12–13; 4:1–8, 14.
- h (2:23) The barley harvest, beginning in March–April, was followed by the wheat harvest, which ended around Pentecost/Shavuot in the third month, Sivan (in May–June): about seven weeks in all.

Chapter 3

1 Her mother-in-law Naomi then said, “My daughter, should I not look
for a secure home for you, where things will go well for you? 2 Boaz,
whose women you worked beside, is our kinsman. Tonight he will
be winnowing his barley on the threshing floor. 3 So bathe, put on
perfume, dress in your best cloak,[a] and go to the threshing floor. Keep
out of his sight until he has finished his meal and drink. 4 When he
lies down, make a mental note of where he sleeps. Go there, lift the
cover from his feet, and lie down. He will explain what you should
do.” 5 Ruth told her, “Whatever you tell me,[b] I will carry out.”
6 She went down to the threshing floor and carried out all her mother-
in-law’s instructions. 7 After Boaz had finished eating and drinking,
and was in good spirits, he went to sleep beside the grain pile. She
slipped in quietly, lifted the covering from his feet, and lay down. 8 In
the middle of the night the man woke with a start, rolled over, and
discovered a woman lying by his feet! 9 He said, “Who are you?” And
she answered, “I am Ruth, your female servant. Spread your wing[c]
over your female servant, for you are a family redeemer.” 10 He said,

"Yahweh bless you, my daughter! This latest act of loyalty is even
finer than your first, since you have not chased after the younger
men, rich or poor. 11 Now, my daughter, have no fear. I will do every-
thing you request, since everyone in my town's gate[d] knows you
are a woman of excellent character. 12 It is true that I am a kinsman-
redeemer. Yet there is another man who is a nearer relative than I
am. 13 Stay here for the night. In the morning, if he is willing to act
as your redeemer, fine, let him do so. If he is unwilling, then I swear
by the life of Yahweh that I will redeem you myself. Now sleep until
morning."
14 She slept by his feet till dawn, and got up while it was still too dark
for anyone to make out a face. He said, "No one must find out that
a woman visited the threshing floor." 15 Then he said, "Hand me the
cloak you have on, and hold it open." She held it out, and he scooped
in six measures[e] of barley, laying the load across her shoulders.
Then she[f] returned to the town. 16 When she reached her mother-in-
law, Naomi inquired, "How did things turn out, my daughter?" Ruth
recounted everything the man had done for her, 17 and added, "These
six measures of barley are his gift to me, because he told me,[g] 'Do not
go home to your mother-in-law with nothing.'" 18 Naomi answered,
"Sit tight, my daughter, until you find out how things stand. The man
will not relax until he has settled this affair today."

Notes

- a (3:3) So the traditional reading (qere), "go down"; the written Hebrew text (ketiv) has "I will go down." A similar difference occurs in verse 4 ("lie down").
- b (3:5) The traditional reading (qere) adds "to me."
- c (3:9) Hebrew kanaf, "wing" or "edge of a garment," a request for marriage and protection; compare 2:12 and Ezekiel 16:8.
- d (3:11) Hebrew "all the gate of my people."
- e (3:15) The Hebrew does not name the unit. Six ephahs would be far too heavy to carry; six seahs (about 4 bushels, 1 seah being about 7.3 liters) or six omers would be possible. The Septuagint reads "six measures."
- f (3:15) So most Hebrew manuscripts. Some Hebrew manuscripts, the Syriac, and the Latin Vulgate read "she."
- g (3:17) The traditional reading (qere) adds "to me"; the written Hebrew text (ketiv) lacks it.

Chapter 4

1 Meanwhile Boaz climbed to the town gate and seated himself there.
Just then the redeemer he had mentioned walked past. Boaz called,
"Come over, my friend,[a] and sit here." So he came over and sat. 2
And he took ten men of the elders of the city and said, "Sit down
here." So they sat down. 3 He addressed the redeemer: "Naomi, who
has returned from Moab, is putting up for sale the plot that belonged
to our kinsman Elimelech. 4 I decided to bring it to your attention:
purchase it before these people seated here and before my people's
elders. If you want to redeem it, do so. If you[b] don't, tell me so that I
know, because nobody else has the right to redeem it except you, and
I am next after you." He answered, "I will redeem it." 5 Boaz continued,
"On the day you acquire the land from Naomi, you also take on[c] Ruth
the Moabite, the dead man's widow, so that his name will be carried
on with his inherited property." 6 The redeemer answered, "Then I am
unable to redeem it, since that could ruin my own estate. You exercise
my redemption right yourself, because I cannot."
7 In earlier days in Israel, this was how redemption and exchange were
validated: one party removed his sandal and handed it to the other.
That was the way of making a transaction official in Israel. 8 So when
the redeemer told Boaz, "Purchase it yourself," he took off his sandal. 9
Boaz addressed the elders and everyone present: "Today you are wit-
nesses that I am buying from Naomi every possession of Elimelech,
Chilion, and Mahlon. 10 I am also taking Ruth the Moabite, Mahlon's
widow, to be my wife, so that the dead man's name will continue
on his inherited land and not disappear from his family or from the
records at his hometown's gate. Today you are my witnesses." 11 All
the people gathered at the gate, along with the elders, answered, "We
are witnesses! May Yahweh make the wife entering your home like
Rachel and Leah, the two who together built the family of Israel.
May you prosper in Ephrathah and gain fame in Bethlehem. 12 and
may your family prosper like Perez's, the son Tamar bore for Judah,
through the children Yahweh gives you by this young woman."
13 So Boaz took Ruth, and she became his wife. And he went in to her,
and Yahweh gave her conception, and she bore a son. 14 The women

told Naomi, “Praise be to Yahweh, who has not left you today without a family redeemer! May the child’s name become famous throughout Israel! 15 He will restore your vitality and care for you when you are old, for he was born to your daughter-in-law. She loves you, and she has proven better to you than seven sons.” 16 Naomi picked up the baby, held him against her chest, and took care of him. 17 The neighbor women gave him his name, announcing, “Naomi has a son!” They called him Obed.[d] He would become Jesse’s father, and so David’s grandfather.

18 This is the genealogy of Perez. To Perez was born Hezron, 19 to Hezron was born Ram, to Ram was born Amminadab, 20 to Amminadab was born Nahshon, to Nahshon was born Salmah,[e] 21 Salmon fathered Boaz, Boaz fathered Obed, 22 Obed fathered Jesse, and Jesse fathered David.

Notes

- a (4:1) Hebrew peloni almoni, “so-and-so,” an expression used when a name is withheld.
- b (4:4) So many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, the Syriac, and the Latin Vulgate. The Hebrew text reads “if he.”
- c (4:5) So the traditional reading (qere), the Septuagint, and the Latin Vulgate (“you acquire”). The written Hebrew text (ketiv) reads “I acquire.” The Hebrew text also reads “and from Ruth”; the translation follows a widely accepted correction, “also Ruth” (compare verse 10).
- d (4:17) Obed means “servant” or “worshiper,” perhaps short for Obadiah, “servant of Yahweh.”
- e (4:20) Hebrew Salmah; in verse 21 Salmon. The Septuagint has “Salmon” in both verses.

1 Samuel

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 There was a certain man from Ramathaim-zophim,[a] in the hill
country of Ephraim, whose name was Elkanah[b] son of Jeroham, son
of Elihu, son of Tohu, son of Zuph, an Ephraimite. 2 He had two wives.
One was named Hannah[c] and the other Peninnah.[d] Peninnah had
children, but Hannah had none.
3 That man would go up from his town each year to bow down and
sacrifice to Yahweh[e] of Armies[f] at Shiloh,[g] where Eli's[h] two sons,
Hophni[i] and Phinehas,[j] were Yahweh's priests. 4 On the day when
Elkanah sacrificed, he gave shares of the meat to Peninnah his wife
and to each of her sons and daughters, 5 but to Hannah he gave a
double share,[k] for it was Hannah he loved, though Yahweh had shut
up her womb. 6 Her rival would taunt her bitterly to provoke her,
because Yahweh had closed her womb. 7 So it went on year after
year. Every time Hannah went up to the house of Yahweh, her rival
provoked her, and she wept and would not eat. 8 Her husband Elkanah
would say to her, "Hannah, why are you crying? Why will you not
eat? Why is your heart so sad? Am I not worth more to you than
ten sons?"
9 One time at Shiloh, when the meal of eating and drinking was over,
Hannah stood up.[l] The priest Eli was seated on a chair by the doorpost
of Yahweh's temple. 10 Deeply distressed, she prayed to Yahweh and
wept bitterly. 11 She took a vow: "Yahweh of Armies, if you will look
closely at your servant's suffering and remember me, if you will not
forget me but give your servant a baby boy, I will give him to Yahweh
for as long as he lives, and a razor will never be used on his head."[m]
12 As she kept on praying before Yahweh, Eli was watching her mouth.
13 Hannah was speaking in her heart; only her lips were moving, and
her voice could not be heard. So Eli supposed she was drunk. 14 Eli

said to her, "How long will you go on being drunk? Get rid of your wine." 15 Hannah replied, "No, my lord, I am a woman with a heavy heart. I have had no wine or beer; I have been pouring out my soul to Yahweh. 16 Do not count your servant as a worthless woman,[n] for all this time I have been speaking out of my great anguish and grief." 17 Eli said, "Go in peace, and may the God of Israel give you the request you made to him." 18 "May your servant find favor with you," she said. Then the woman left and had something to eat, and her face did not look sad any longer.[o]

19 They rose early in the morning and bowed down before Yahweh; then they went back home to Ramah. Elkanah knew his wife Hannah, and Yahweh remembered her. 20 When the time came, Hannah conceived and gave birth to a son. She called him Samuel,[p] explaining, "I asked Yahweh for him."

21 Then Elkanah went up, he and his whole household, to offer Yahweh the yearly sacrifice and to pay his vow. 22 But Hannah did not go up. She told her husband, "Not until the child is weaned. Then I will take him, and he will appear before Yahweh and stay there for good."[q] 23 Her husband Elkanah said to her, "Do whatever you think is good. Wait here until you have weaned him. Only may Yahweh confirm his word."[r] So the woman remained and nursed her son until she weaned him. 24 When she had weaned him, she took him up with her, along with a three-year-old bull,[s] about three-fifths of a bushel of flour,[t] and a skin of wine, and brought him to the house of Yahweh at Shiloh. The child was still young. 25 Then they slaughtered the bull and took the boy to Eli. 26 She said, "Excuse me, my lord! As you live, my lord, I am that woman who was standing near you here, praying to Yahweh. 27 For this child I prayed, and Yahweh has granted me what I asked of him. 28 So I in turn have lent him to Yahweh.[u] For as long as he lives he is lent to Yahweh." And he[v] worshiped Yahweh there.

Notes

- a (1:1) Ramathaim-zophim means "two heights of the Zuphites" (compare "Zuph" later in the verse). The town is called Ramah, "height," in verse 19. The Septuagint reads "Armathaim Zipha" (Brenton, "Armathaim Sipha"); its exact site is uncertain.

- b (1:1) Elkanah means “God has created” or “God has acquired.” The Septuagint spells the names in this genealogy differently (Brenton: Helkana, Jeremeel, Elius, Thocca, Suph).
- c (1:2) Hannah means “grace” or “favor.” The Septuagint spells it “Anna.”
- d (1:2) Peninnah may mean “coral” or “pearl” (uncertain).
- e (1:3) Yahweh is the personal name of Israel’s God (Hebrew YHWH), which many English versions replace with “the LORD.” This translation writes the name.
- f (1:3) Hebrew Yahweh tseba’ot, traditionally “the LORD of hosts” (or “Yahweh Sabaoth”). The armies may be Israel’s forces, the heavenly host, or both. This is the first time the title appears in the Bible; it occurs often in Samuel, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. The Septuagint keeps the Hebrew word: “Lord God of Sabaoth” (Brenton, 1:11).
- g (1:3) Shiloh, where the tent of meeting stood in this period (Joshua 18:1), is about 20 miles (30 kilometers) north of Jerusalem; the name may mean “place of rest” (uncertain).
- h (1:3) Eli probably means “exalted” or “my God” (uncertain).
- i (1:3) Hophni is probably an Egyptian name, perhaps “tadpole” (uncertain).
- j (1:3) Phinehas is an Egyptian name meaning “the Nubian.”
- k (1:5) The Hebrew is difficult. Literally “one portion of two faces,” perhaps “a double portion” or “a choice portion”; some take it to mean “only one portion.” The Septuagint reads “a prime portion, because she had no child” (Brenton).
- l (1:9) The Septuagint adds, “and stood before the Lord” (Brenton).
- m (1:11) The Septuagint adds, “and he will drink no wine or strong drink” (Brenton, modernized). Compare the Nazirite vow in Numbers 6:1–8 and Samson in Judges 13:5.
- n (1:16) Hebrew “a daughter of Belial,” an expression for a worthless or wicked person.
- o (1:18) The Septuagint reads, “and entered into her lodging, and ate and drank with her husband” (Brenton, modernized).
- p (1:20) Samuel (Hebrew Shemu’el) probably means “name of God” or “heard by God.” Hannah’s explanation is a wordplay on the verb sha’al, “to ask,” which is the root of the name Saul (Sha’ul). The pun may hint at the story of Saul, the king Israel “asked for” (8:10; 12:13).
- q (1:22) Or “for all time.” 4QSam-a is reported to add that she would dedicate him as a Nazirite for all time (compare verse 11).
- r (1:23) So the traditional Hebrew text (MT). The Septuagint reads “may the Lord establish that which comes out of your mouth” (Brenton, modernized), and 4QSam-a is reported to agree with the Greek.
- s (1:24) So the Septuagint (Brenton, “a calf of three years old”), 4QSam-a (as reported), and other ancient witnesses. The traditional Hebrew text reads “with three bulls,” but verse 25 mentions only one bull; dividing the Hebrew letters differently gives “a three-year-old bull.”

- t (1:24) Hebrew "an ephah of flour," a dry measure of about 22 liters.
- u (1:28) Hebrew sha'ul, "asked" or "lent," the same form as the name Saul. The verse plays on the root "ask" used in verses 17, 20, and 27.
- v (1:28) That is, Elkanah, or possibly Samuel. Some Hebrew manuscripts read "they." The Septuagint instead reads "and she said" (Brenton) and goes straight into Hannah's song.

Chapter 2

1 Then Hannah prayed and said,[a] "My heart exults in Yahweh; my horn[b] is raised high in Yahweh.[c] My mouth gapes wide against my enemies, for I take joy in your rescue. 2 No one is holy like Yahweh; indeed, there is no one besides you, and there is no rock like our God.[d] 3 Stop piling up proud words; let no arrogance come from your mouth, for Yahweh is a God who knows, and by him actions are weighed.[e] 4 The bows of the mighty are broken, while those who stumbled are wrapped in strength. 5 Those who had plenty now hire themselves out for bread, while the hungry hunger no more.[f] The childless woman has borne seven, but the mother of many pines away. 6 Yahweh puts to death and brings to life; he brings down to Sheol[g] and raises up. 7 Yahweh makes poor and makes rich; he humbles, and he also exalts. 8 He lifts the poor from the dust; from the ash heap he raises the needy, to seat them with nobles and give them a throne of honor as their inheritance. For the pillars of the earth belong to Yahweh, and on them he has set the world.[h] 9 He guards the feet of his faithful ones, but the wicked are silenced in darkness, for no one prevails by strength. 10 Those who contend with Yahweh will be shattered;[i] he will thunder against them from heaven. Yahweh will judge to the ends of the earth; he will give power to his king and lift up the horn of his anointed."[j]

11 Then Elkanah went home to Ramah, but the boy remained to serve Yahweh in the presence of Eli the priest.[k]

12 Eli's sons, however, were scoundrels;[l] they paid no attention to Yahweh 13 or to what the priests were entitled to from the people.[m] Each time someone offered a sacrifice, the priest's servant would arrive with a three-pronged fork in his hand while the meat was still boiling, 14 and he would thrust it into the pan or kettle or cauldron or pot. Whatever the fork brought up, the priest took for himself. This is

how they treated all the Israelites who came there to Shiloh. 15 What
is more, even before they burned the fat, the priest's servant used to
come and tell the man offering the sacrifice, "Hand over meat for the
priest to roast. He will not accept boiled meat from you, only raw."
16 And if the man answered him, "The fat must be burned first; after
that, take as much as you like," he would reply, "No, you will hand
it over now, and if not, I will take it by force." 17 So the young men's
sin was very great in Yahweh's sight, for the men treated Yahweh's
offering with contempt.
18 But Samuel was serving before Yahweh, a boy dressed in a linen
ephod.[n] 19 Every year his mother would make him a little robe and
bring it to him when she came up with her husband to offer the yearly
sacrifice. 20 And Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife and say, "May
Yahweh give you offspring from this woman in exchange for the one
she asked for and lent to Yahweh."[o] Then they would return home. 21
Yahweh visited Hannah, and she conceived and bore three sons and
two daughters. Meanwhile the boy Samuel grew up before Yahweh.
22 Now Eli was very old, and word kept reaching him of everything his
sons were doing to all Israel and of how they lay with the women who
served at the door of the tent of meeting.[p] 23 He said to them, "Why
do you do such things? From all these people I hear reports of your
wicked deeds. 24 No, my sons. What I hear Yahweh's people spreading
about you is not a good report. 25 If one person sins against another,
God[q] may mediate for him; but if someone sins against Yahweh, who
can plead for him?" But they would not listen to their father, for it
was Yahweh's will to put them to death.
26 Meanwhile the boy Samuel kept growing, both in stature and in
favor with Yahweh and with people.
27 A man of God came to Eli and said to him, "This is what Yahweh
says: 'Did I not reveal myself plainly to your father's house when
they were in Egypt, slaves to Pharaoh's house?[r] 28 Out of all the tribes
of Israel I chose him to be my priest, to go up to my altar, to burn
incense, and to carry the ephod before me. I gave your father's house
all the food offerings of the Israelites. 29 Why then do you trample[s] on
my sacrifices and on the offerings I ordered for my dwelling? Why do

you honor your sons above me, growing fat on the best part of every offering of Israel my people?' 30 "Therefore Yahweh, the God of Israel, declares: 'I said that your house and your father's house would walk before me forever.' But now Yahweh declares: 'Far be it from me! For I honor only those who honor me, and those who think little of me will be brought low. 31 Look, days are coming when I will cut off your arm[t] and the arm of your father's house, until there is no old man left in your house. 32 You will look with envy on all the good that is done for Israel,[u] and never will there be an old man in your house. 33 Any of yours whom I do not cut off from my altar will be spared only to wear out your[v] eyes and grieve your heart, and all the increase of your house will die as men in their prime.[w] 34 And what happens to your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, will be the sign to you: on one day both of them will die. 35 I will raise up for myself a faithful priest, who will act in keeping with what is in my heart and mind. I will build him a lasting house, and he will walk before my anointed one forever. 36 Whoever is left in your house will come and bow down to him for a small silver coin[x] or a loaf of bread, and will say, "Please assign me to one of the priestly duties, so that I can have a scrap of bread to eat."'"

Notes

- a (2:1) The Song of Hannah (2:1–10) is a poem of praise for God who reverses human fortunes; compare Mary's song in Luke 1:46–55. The Septuagint and 4QSam-a differ from the traditional Hebrew text in several lines, as noted below. This needs scholarly review.
- b (2:1) The horn is an image of strength and dignity, taken from the horns of a wild ox.
- c (2:1) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "in my God" (Brenton), and some Hebrew manuscripts are reported to agree.
- d (2:2) The Septuagint reads "For there is none holy as the Lord, and there is none righteous as our God: there is none holy besides you" (Brenton, modernized), without the line about the rock.
- e (2:3) Or "and actions are not weighed," following the written Hebrew (ketiv), which has "not" rather than "by him." The Septuagint reads "and God prepares his own designs" (Brenton, modernized).
- f (2:5) Hebrew uncertain; literally "and the hungry cease." The Septuagint reads "and the hungry have forsaken the land" (Brenton).
- g (2:6) Sheol is the realm of the dead (the grave, the underworld).

- h (2:8) The Septuagint lacks these two lines and instead reads, "granting his request to the one who prays; and he blesses the years of the righteous" (Brenton, modernized), at the start of verse 9; it also lacks the first two lines of verse 9 as they stand in Hebrew. 4QSam-a is reported to agree with the Greek here in part.
- i (2:10) So the Hebrew as traditionally read (qere); the written text (ketiv) has the singular, "the one who contends with him." The Septuagint reads, "The Lord will weaken his adversary; the Lord is holy" (Brenton).
- j (2:10) Hebrew mashiaḥ, "anointed one," from which the title "Messiah" comes. In the Septuagint, this verse is much longer. After "the Lord is holy" it adds, in words close to Jeremiah 9:23–24: "Let the wise man not boast in his wisdom, nor the mighty man in his strength, nor the rich man in his wealth; but let the one who boasts boast in this, to understand and know the Lord, and to do justice and righteousness in the midst of the earth" (Brenton, modernized). 4QSam-a is reported to contain part of this addition. This needs scholarly review.
- k (2:11) The Septuagint begins the verse, "And she left him there before the Lord, and departed to Armathaim" (Brenton, modernized).
- l (2:12) Hebrew "sons of Belial," that is, worthless or wicked men.
- m (2:13) Or "the priests' custom with the people." Hebrew mishpat, "judgment, right, custom." Compare the priests' legal portion in Leviticus 7:31–34 and Deuteronomy 18:3.
- n (2:18) The linen ephod here is a simple priestly garment worn by those serving at the sanctuary (compare 22:18; 2 Samuel 6:14), not the high priest's ornate ephod of Exodus 28.
- o (2:20) So 4QSam-a (as reported) and the Septuagint (Brenton, "in return for the loan which you have lent to the Lord," modernized). The traditional Hebrew text reads "in place of the request which he asked of Yahweh." Again the verb plays on the name Saul (see 1:20).
- p (2:22) The Septuagint lacks this clause about the women at the entrance (Brenton), and 4QSam-a is reported to lack it as well. Compare Exodus 38:8.
- q (2:25) Or "the judges" (Hebrew 'elohim). God, or those acting for him, can settle a dispute between people.
- r (2:27) The Septuagint reads "when they were servants in Egypt to the house of Pharaoh" (Brenton, modernized), and 4QSam-a is reported to have "servants."
- s (2:29) Hebrew uncertain; literally "kick at" (compare Deuteronomy 32:15). The Septuagint reads "look upon … with a shameless eye" (Brenton, modernized).
- t (2:31) The arm is a symbol of strength and vigor.
- u (2:32) Hebrew uncertain; literally "you will see an adversary of the dwelling in all that he does good to Israel." The Septuagint lacks this line (Brenton).
- v (2:33) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "his eyes … his soul" (Brenton), and 4QSam-a is reported to agree.
- w (2:33) So the traditional Hebrew text, "will die as men." The Septuagint reads "will fall by the sword of men" (Brenton), and 4QSam-a is reported to agree.

- x (2:36) Hebrew 'agorah, a small coin or weight of silver, probably a fraction of a shekel (11.5 grams). The exact value is unknown.

Chapter 3

1 The boy Samuel was serving Yahweh under Eli. In those days the
word of Yahweh was rare; visions did not come often.[a]
2 At that time Eli, whose eyes had grown so dim that he was unable to
see, was lying in his usual place. 3 The lamp of God had not yet gone
out,[b] and Samuel was lying down in the temple of Yahweh, where
the ark of God was. 4 Then Yahweh called Samuel,[c] and he answered,
"Here I am!" 5 He ran to Eli and said, "Here I am, for you called me."
Eli said, "I did not call. Lie down again." And he went and lay down.
6 Yahweh called yet again, "Samuel!" Samuel got up, went to Eli, and
said, "Here I am, for you called me." Eli answered, "I did not call, my
son. Lie down again." 7 Samuel did not yet know Yahweh: the word of
Yahweh had not yet been revealed to him. 8 Yahweh called Samuel a
third time. Samuel rose and went to Eli. "Here I am," he said, "since
you called me." Then Eli realized that it was Yahweh who was calling
the boy. 9 Eli told Samuel, "Go back to bed, and if he calls you, say,
'Speak, Yahweh, for your servant is listening.'" Samuel went and lay
in his own place.
10 Yahweh came and stood there, and called as he had the other times,
"Samuel! Samuel!" And Samuel said, "Speak, for your servant is
listening." 11 Yahweh said to Samuel, "Watch: I am about to do a thing
in Israel that will make both ears of everyone who hears of it ring.
12 On that day I will carry out against Eli everything I have spoken
about his house, from beginning to end. 13 I have told him that I am
going to judge his house for all time, for the iniquity that he knew of:
his sons were bringing a curse on themselves,[d] and he did not restrain
them. 14 Therefore I have sworn to the house of Eli that the guilt of
Eli's house will never be wiped away by sacrifice or offering."
15 Samuel stayed in bed until morning, and then he unlocked the doors
of Yahweh's house. He was afraid to report the vision to Eli. 16 Then Eli
called Samuel and said, "Samuel, my son." He answered, "Here I am."
17 Eli asked, "What was the word he spoke to you? Do not hide it from

me. May God deal with you severely, and more so, if you hide from me anything of all that he told you." 18 So Samuel told him everything and hid nothing from him. Then Eli said, "He is Yahweh. Let him do what seems good to him."

19 Samuel grew up, and Yahweh was with him and let none of his words fall to the ground.[e] 20 All Israel from Dan to Beersheba[f] recognized that Samuel had been confirmed as a prophet of Yahweh. 21 Yahweh continued to appear at Shiloh, for at Shiloh Yahweh revealed himself to Samuel through the word of Yahweh.[g]

Notes

- a (3:1) Literally "vision was not breaking through." The Septuagint reads "there was no distinct vision" (Brenton).
- b (3:3) That is, it was still night, before dawn. The lampstand in the sanctuary burned from evening until morning (Exodus 27:20–21; Leviticus 24:2–3).
- c (3:4) The Septuagint reads "called Samuel, Samuel" (Brenton has "called, Samuel, Samuel"), and some ancient witnesses agree; compare verse 10.
- d (3:13) So the traditional Hebrew text, "were cursing themselves" (or "were treating it lightly"). The Septuagint reads "his sons spoke evil against God" (Brenton). Jewish tradition lists this verse among the places where scribes altered "God" to avoid writing a curse against him, and many scholars think "cursing God" is original.
- e (3:19) That is, everything Samuel said came true.
- f (3:20) Dan in the far north and Beersheba in the south; the phrase means the whole land.
- g (3:21) The Septuagint adds, "and Samuel was trusted by all Israel as a prophet of the Lord from one end of the land to the other; and Eli was very old, and his sons kept going on in wickedness, and their way was evil before the Lord" (Brenton, modernized). Some of this may belong with 4:1.

Chapter 4

1 And the word of Samuel came to all Israel. Now Israel went out to meet the Philistines in battle.[a] They pitched camp beside Ebenezer,[b] while the Philistines pitched camp in Aphek. 2 The Philistines arrayed themselves against Israel, and when the battle spread out, Israel was struck down before the Philistines, and about four thousand men were killed in the ranks in the field. 3 When the army came back to camp, the elders of Israel asked, "Why did Yahweh bring defeat on us today at the hands of the Philistines? Let us fetch the ark of Yahweh's

covenant from Shiloh, so that it will be with us and deliver us from our enemies' grasp." 4 The people therefore sent men to Shiloh and had them bring from there the ark of the covenant of Yahweh of Armies, who sits above the cherubim.[c] Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, accompanied the ark of God's covenant.
5 When the ark of Yahweh's covenant came into the camp, all Israel shouted with a great shout, so that the earth rang. 6 Hearing the noise of the shouting, the Philistines said, "What is this great shouting in the Hebrews' camp?" When they learned that the ark of Yahweh had come into the camp, 7 the Philistines were frightened. They said, "God has come into the camp."[d] And they said, "Woe to us! Nothing like this has happened before. 8 Who will deliver us from the power of these mighty gods? They are the very gods who struck down the Egyptians with all sorts of plagues in the wilderness.[e] 9 Take courage and be men, Philistines, or you will end up serving the Hebrews just as they have served you. Be men and fight!"
10 So the Philistines fought, and Israel was defeated, and every man fled to his tent. The slaughter was very great: thirty thousand foot soldiers of Israel fell. 11 The ark of God was taken, and both sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, died.
12 A Benjamite ran from the battle ranks and reached Shiloh that same day, his clothes torn and earth on his head.[f] 13 When he arrived, Eli was sitting on his seat beside the road, watching,[g] for his heart trembled for the ark of God. When the man came into the town to tell the news, the whole town cried out. 14 Hearing the sound of the outcry, Eli asked, "What is this uproar?" The man hurried over and told Eli. 15 Eli was ninety-eight years old,[h] and his eyes were fixed so that he could not see. 16 The man said to Eli, "I have come from the battle; I fled from the ranks today." Eli asked, "How did things go, my son?" 17 The messenger answered, "Israel has fled before the Philistines, and there has been a great slaughter among the troops. Your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, are dead, and the ark of God has been taken."
18 At the mention of the ark of God, Eli toppled backward off his seat beside the gate, broke his neck, and died, for he was an old man and heavy. He had judged Israel forty years.[i]

19 Now the wife of Phinehas, his daughter-in-law, was with child and
close to delivery. Hearing the report that the ark of God was taken
and that her father-in-law and husband were dead, she bent down
and gave birth, for her pains came upon her suddenly. 20 As she was
dying, the women attending her said, "Do not be afraid, for you have
given birth to a son." But she did not answer or pay attention. 21 She
named the boy Ichabod,[j] saying, "The glory has gone into exile from
Israel," because of the capture of the ark of God and because of her
father-in-law and her husband. 22 She said, "The glory has gone into
exile from Israel, for the ark of God has been taken."

Notes

- a (4:1) The Septuagint begins, "And it came to pass in those days that the Philistines gathered themselves together against Israel to war, and Israel went out to meet them" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (4:1) Ebenezer means "stone of help." The place receives this name in 7:12; the narrator uses the name known to his readers.
- c (4:4) The cherubim were winged figures above the cover of the ark (Exodus 25:18–22), pictured as the throne of the invisible God.
- d (4:7) Or "gods have come into the camp." The Septuagint reads "These are the gods that have come to them into the camp" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (4:8) Or "with every kind of plague and in the wilderness." The Philistines' version of the exodus story is confused, which may be intended. The Septuagint reads "with every plague, and in the wilderness" (Brenton).
- f (4:12) Torn clothes and earth on the head were signs of mourning and disaster.
- g (4:13) So the traditional reading. The written Hebrew (ketiv) is unclear; the Septuagint reads "upon the seat by the gate looking along the way" (Brenton).
- h (4:15) The Septuagint reads "ninety years old" (Brenton).
- i (4:18) The Septuagint reads "twenty years" (Brenton).
- j (4:21) Ichabod is usually understood as "Where is the glory?" or "No glory." The Septuagint has a different form, "Uaibarchaboth" (Brenton, "Uæbarchaboth"), perhaps meaning "Woe for the glory."

Chapter 5

1 After capturing the ark of God, the Philistines carried it from
Ebenezer to Ashdod.[a] 2 The Philistines took the ark of God, carried it
into the temple of Dagon,[b] and set it up beside Dagon. 3 The people
of Ashdod rose early the following morning, and there was Dagon,
lying face down on the ground in front of Yahweh's ark. They lifted

Dagon up and set him in his place again. 4 But when they got up
early the following morning, there was Dagon again, fallen on his
face to the ground before the ark of Yahweh. Dagon's head and both
his hands lay broken off on the threshold; only his trunk[c] was left. 5
That is why, to this day, neither the priests of Dagon nor anyone who
enters Dagon's temple steps on the threshold of Dagon in Ashdod.
6 Yahweh's hand weighed heavily on the people of Ashdod. He
devastated them and struck them with tumors,[d] both Ashdod and its
territory. 7 When the people of Ashdod realized what was going on,
they said, "The ark of Israel's God cannot remain with us, because his
hand is heavy on us and on our god Dagon." 8 So they sent for all the
rulers of the Philistines,[e] gathered them, and asked, "What should we
do with the ark of the God of Israel?" They answered, "Let the ark
of the God of Israel be moved on to Gath." So they moved the ark of
the God of Israel there. 9 But after they had moved it, Yahweh's hand
was against that city, causing a very great panic. He struck the people
of the city, from the least to the greatest, and tumors broke out on
them. 10 Next they sent the ark of God off to Ekron. As the ark of God
entered Ekron, the Ekronites shouted, "They have carried the ark of
the God of Israel to us so that it will kill us and our people!" 11 They
sent and gathered all the rulers of the Philistines and said, "Send off
the ark of the God of Israel and let it return to where it belongs, or it
will kill us and our people." For deadly panic had gripped the whole
city; God's hand was very heavy there. 12 And the men who did not
die were struck with the tumors, and the cry of the city rose up to
the heavens.

Notes

- a (5:1) Ashdod, Gath, and Ekron (verses 8–10), with Gaza and Ashkelon, were the five chief cities of the Philistines (6:17). The Septuagint calls them Azotus, Geth, Accaron, Gaza, and Ascalon (Brenton); at verse 10 it reads "Ascalon" instead of Ekron.
- b (5:2) Dagon was a West Semitic grain god worshiped by the Philistines (Judges 16:23). The name is probably related to dagan, "grain," though it was once linked with dag, "fish."
- c (5:4) So the Septuagint, "stump" or "trunk" (Brenton, "stump"). The traditional Hebrew text reads "only Dagon was left on him."

- d (5:6) Hebrew ʾophalim, probably swellings or boils (perhaps the buboes of bubonic plague); the traditional reading (qere) is teḥorim, a word of similar meaning. The Septuagint adds that the hand of the Lord "brought evil upon them, and it burst out upon them into the ships, and mice sprang up in the midst of their country, and there was a great and indiscriminate death in the city" (Brenton, modernized). Compare the gold mice in 6:4–5.
- e (5:8) Hebrew seren, a title used only of the Philistine rulers, perhaps related to the Greek word tyrannos, "ruler."

Chapter 6

1 The ark of Yahweh had been in Philistine territory for seven
months.[a] 2 Then the Philistines called in the priests and the diviners
and asked, "What should we do with the ark of Yahweh? Tell us
how we should send it back to its place." 3 They replied, "If you send
away the ark of the God of Israel, do not send it away empty, but
by all means pay him back with a guilt offering.[b] Then you will be
healed, and you will learn why his hand has not turned away from
you." 4 "What is the guilt offering we should send him?" they asked.
They replied, "Five gold tumors and five gold mice, one apiece for
the Philistine rulers, since there was a single plague on all of you
and your rulers alike. 5 So make models of your tumors and models
of the mice that are ravaging the land, and give glory to the God of
Israel. Perhaps he will lighten his hand on you, on your gods, and on
your land. 6 Why should you harden your hearts as the Egyptians and
Pharaoh hardened their hearts? After he had dealt harshly with them,
did they not let the people go, and they departed? 7 So now prepare
a new cart, and take two milk cows that have never borne a yoke.
Harness the cows to the cart, and bring their calves home behind
them. 8 Then take Yahweh's ark and load it on the cart. Place the gold
objects that you are sending as a guilt offering in a box beside it, and
send it off to go its way. 9 And watch: if it goes up by the road to its
own territory, toward Beth-shemesh,[c] then it is he who has brought
this great disaster on us. But if not, we will know that it was not his
hand that struck us; it happened to us by chance."
10 The men did so. They took two cows that had calved and hitched
them to the cart, and shut their calves up at home. 11 They put the

ark of Yahweh on the cart, together with the box holding the gold mice and the models of their tumors. 12 The cows took the straight way along the road to Beth-shemesh. They went on the one highway, lowing as they walked, turning neither right nor left, while the rulers of the Philistines walked behind them up to the edge of Beth-shemesh.

13 The people of Beth-shemesh were harvesting wheat in the valley.[d] When they looked up and saw the ark, they were overjoyed. 14 The cart reached the field of Joshua of Beth-shemesh and halted beside a large stone. The people chopped up the cart's wood and offered the cows as a burnt offering to Yahweh. 15 The Levites lifted down Yahweh's ark along with the box that held the gold objects and set them on the large stone. On that day the men of Beth-shemesh presented burnt offerings and other sacrifices to Yahweh. 16 When the five rulers of the Philistines had seen this, they returned to Ekron that same day.

17 These are the gold tumors which the Philistines paid back to Yahweh as a guilt offering: one for Ashdod, one for Gaza, one for Ashkelon, one for Gath, one for Ekron. 18 The number of gold mice equaled the number of Philistine cities under the five rulers, both fortified cities and country villages. The large stone[e] where they placed Yahweh's ark still stands as a witness in the field of Joshua of Beth-shemesh.

19 But Yahweh struck down some of the men of Beth-shemesh because they looked into the ark of Yahweh. He struck down seventy men[f] of the people. And the people mourned because Yahweh had struck the people with a great slaughter. 20 The men of Beth-shemesh asked, "Who is able to stand in the presence of Yahweh, this holy God? Where can the ark go from here, away from us?" 21 They sent messengers to the inhabitants of Kiriath-jearim[g] with this message: "The Philistines have brought back Yahweh's ark. Come down and carry it up to your town."

Notes

- a (6:1) The Septuagint adds, "and their land brought forth swarms of mice" (Brenton, modernized).

- b (6:3) Hebrew 'asham, the offering that makes amends for a wrong done (Leviticus 5:14–6:7).
- c (6:9) Beth-shemesh means "house of the sun." It lay in Israelite territory about 15 miles (24 kilometers) west of Jerusalem.
- d (6:13) The wheat harvest came in May–June.
- e (6:18) So some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint (Brenton, "the great stone"). The traditional Hebrew text reads "Abel," perhaps "meadow" or "mourning." The Hebrew words for "stone" and "meadow" differ by one letter.
- f (6:19) So some Hebrew manuscripts and Josephus (as reported). Most Hebrew manuscripts read "seventy men, fifty thousand men," and the Septuagint reads "seventy men, and fifty thousand men" (Brenton). The larger figure, oddly attached without "and" in the Hebrew, is probably a later addition. The Septuagint also begins the verse differently: "And the sons of Jechonias were not pleased with the men of Bethshemesh, because they saw the ark of the Lord" (Brenton, modernized).
- g (6:21) Kiriath-jearim means "town of forests." It lay about 9 miles (15 kilometers) west of Jerusalem.

Chapter 7

1 So the men of Kiriath-jearim came and brought up the ark of Yahweh
and took it into the house of Abinadab[a] on the hill, and they set apart
Eleazar his son to keep watch over the ark of Yahweh.
2 From the day the ark came to rest at Kiriath-jearim, a long time
passed, twenty years in all, and the whole house of Israel mourned[b]
after Yahweh. 3 Samuel told all the house of Israel, "If you are coming
back to Yahweh with your whole heart, remove the foreign gods and
the Ashtoreths[c] from your midst. Direct your hearts to Yahweh and
serve only him, and he will deliver you from Philistine rule." 4 So the
Israelites removed the Baals[d] and the Ashtoreths and served Yahweh
alone.
5 Then Samuel said, "Bring all Israel together at Mizpah,[e] and I will
pray to Yahweh for you." 6 So they gathered at Mizpah, drew water
and poured it out before Yahweh, and fasted that day. There they said,
"We have sinned against Yahweh." And Samuel judged the Israelites
at Mizpah.
7 When the Philistines heard that the Israelites had gathered at
Mizpah, the rulers of the Philistines went up against Israel. Hearing
of it, the Israelites were afraid of the Philistines. 8 The Israelites
said to Samuel, "Keep on crying to Yahweh our God for us, so that

he may rescue us from the Philistines." [9] So Samuel took a nursing lamb and offered it whole as a burnt offering to Yahweh. Samuel cried out to Yahweh for Israel, and Yahweh answered him. [10] While Samuel was presenting the burnt offering, the Philistines moved in to attack Israel. That day, however, Yahweh thundered loudly against the Philistines, threw them into confusion, and they were routed by Israel. [11] The men of Israel went out from Mizpah and chased the Philistines, striking them down as far as a point below Beth-car.[f]
[12] Samuel took a stone, set it up between Mizpah and Shen,[g] and named it Ebenezer,[h] saying, "Yahweh has helped us all the way to here." [13] So the Philistines were humbled and did not again come into Israel's territory. The hand of Yahweh was against the Philistines all the days of Samuel. [14] The towns that the Philistines had taken from Israel were restored to Israel, from Ekron to Gath, and Israel freed their territory from the Philistines' control. There was also peace between Israel and the Amorites.
[15] Samuel judged Israel all the days of his life. [16] Year by year he went on a circuit to Bethel, Gilgal, and Mizpah, and judged Israel at all these places. [17] Then he would return to Ramah, because his house was there, and there too he judged Israel. And he built an altar there to Yahweh.

Notes

- a (7:1) Abinadab means "my father is generous" or "my father is noble." Eleazar means "God has helped."
- b (7:2) Or "longed"; the Hebrew verb is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "all the house of Israel looked after the Lord" (Brenton).
- c (7:3) Ashtoreth (plural Ashtaroth) was a Canaanite goddess of fertility and war, called Astarte by the Greeks. The Hebrew vowels may imitate boshet, "shame."
- d (7:4) Baal, "lord" or "owner," was the Canaanite storm god; the plural refers to his local forms and images.
- e (7:5) Mizpah means "watchtower." This Mizpah was in Benjamin, about 8 miles (13 kilometers) north of Jerusalem.
- f (7:11) Beth-car means "house of the lamb" or "house of pasture" (uncertain); the site is unknown.
- g (7:12) Shen means "tooth," perhaps a rocky crag. The Septuagint reads "the old city" (Brenton), which suggests the Hebrew name Jeshanah (2 Chronicles 13:19).
- h (7:12) Ebenezer means "stone of help."

Chapter 8

1 When Samuel had become old, he made his sons judges over Israel.
2 His firstborn son was named Joel,[a] and his second, Abijah;[b] they
judged at Beersheba. 3 His sons, however, did not walk in his ways
but leaned toward gain; they took bribes and bent justice.
4 So all the elders of Israel gathered together and came to Samuel at
Ramah. 5 They told him, "You have grown old, and your sons do not
live as you have. So now set a king over us to judge us, like all the
other nations." 6 But the request displeased Samuel when they said,
"Give us a king to judge us." So Samuel prayed to Yahweh. 7 Yahweh
said to Samuel, "Listen to the people in all that they tell you, for it
is not you they have rejected, but me; they do not want me to be
king over them. 8 Just as they have done from the day I brought them
up out of Egypt until today, abandoning me and serving other gods,
so they are also doing to you. 9 Now then, listen to them; but warn
them solemnly, and tell them the practice[c] of the king who will reign
over them."
10 So Samuel told all the words of Yahweh to the people who had asked
him for a king. 11 He said, "This will be the king's way with you, the
king who will reign over you: he will take your sons and put them
on his chariots and among his horsemen, and they will run before his
chariots. 12 He will set some as officers over thousands and officers
over fifties, and some to plow his plowland and reap his harvest and
make his weapons and the fittings of his chariots. 13 He will take
your daughters to be perfumers, cooks, and bakers. 14 He will take
your finest fields, vineyards, and olive orchards and give them to his
courtiers. 15 Of your seed and your vineyards he will take a tenth, and
give it to his court officers[d] and his officials. 16 He will take your male
and female slaves, the finest of your young men,[e] and your donkeys,
and put them to work for himself. 17 Of your flocks he will take a tenth,
and you yourselves will be his slaves. 18 On that day you will cry out
because of the king you have chosen for yourselves, but Yahweh will
not answer you on that day."
19 But the people refused to listen to Samuel. "No!" they said. "There
must be a king over us. 20 Then we too will be like all the nations,

and our king will judge us and go out before us and fight our battles."
21 When Samuel had heard all the people's words, he repeated them
in Yahweh's hearing. 22 Yahweh said to Samuel, "Listen to their voice
and make them a king." So Samuel told the men of Israel, "Go, every
man to his own town."

Notes

- a (8:2) Joel means "Yahweh is God."
- b (8:2) Abijah means "my father is Yahweh." The Septuagint calls him "Abia" (Brenton).
- c (8:9) Hebrew mishpat, "judgment, right, custom"; here the king's way of doing things, his claims on the people. Compare Deuteronomy 17:14–20.
- d (8:15) Hebrew saris, often "eunuch," but also used more broadly of a court official.
- e (8:16) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "your good herds" (Brenton), which may reflect a Hebrew word for "cattle" differing by one letter.

Chapter 9

1 There was a man from Benjamin named Kish.[a] He was the son of
Abiel, son of Zeror, son of Becorath, son of Aphiah, a Benjamite and
a man of means and importance.[b] 2 He had a son named Saul,[c] a
fine young man; none of the Israelites was finer than he. From his
shoulders up he stood taller than all the people.
3 Now the she-donkeys belonging to Kish the father of Saul had
wandered off. Kish told Saul his son, "Take along with you one of
the young men, and arise, go and search for the donkeys." 4 He
passed through the hill country of Ephraim and through the land of
Shalishah,[d] but they did not find them. Then they passed through the
land of Shaalim, and they were not there. Then he passed through
the land of Benjamin, and they did not find them.
5 When they reached the land of Zuph, Saul told the young man with
him, "Come, we should go back, lest my father leave off caring about
the donkeys and become anxious over us." 6 But the servant said to
him, "Listen, there is a man of God in this town, and the man is held
in honor; everything he says surely comes about. Let us go there now.
Perhaps he can tell us about the journey we have set out on." 7 Saul
said to his young man, "Suppose we go; what shall we take to the

man? The bread is used up from our sacks, and we have no present to bring the man of God. What is there with us?" [8] The servant answered Saul again, "Look, I have here in my hand a quarter of a silver coin, about a tenth of an ounce.[e] I will give it to the man of God, and he will tell us our way." [9] (Formerly in Israel, a man who set out to inquire of God would say, "Come, let us go to the seer," since today's prophet[f] was called a seer in those days.) [10] Saul said to his servant, "Well spoken. Come, let us go." So they went to the town where the man of God was.

[11] As they climbed the ascent to the town, they came upon girls going out to draw water, and they said to them, "Is the seer here?" [12] "He is," they answered. "He is just ahead of you. Hurry, because he arrived in the town today; the people are holding a sacrifice at the high place[g] today. [13] The moment you go into the town you will find him, before he climbs to the high place to eat. The people will not eat until he comes, for he blesses the sacrifice; afterward those who are invited eat. So go up now, for you will find him at once." [14] So they went up to the town. Just as they were coming into the middle of the town, Samuel came out facing them, going up to the high place.

[15] Now one day before Saul came, Yahweh had revealed this to Samuel:[h] [16] "About this time tomorrow I will send to you a man out of Benjamin's land, and you shall anoint him as leader[i] over my people Israel. He will save my people from the hand of the Philistines, for I have looked upon my people,[j] because their cry has come to me." [17] When Samuel saw Saul, Yahweh told him, "Here is the man I spoke to you about. He is the one who will hold my people in check."[k] [18] Saul approached Samuel in the gateway and said, "Tell me, please, where is the seer's house?" [19] "I am the seer," Samuel replied to Saul. "Walk ahead of me up to the high place; you are to eat with me today. At dawn I will let you go, and I will tell you all that is in your heart. [20] As for your donkeys that were lost three days ago, do not trouble yourself about them, for they have been found. And to whom does all Israel's desire turn, if not to you and to all your father's house?" [21] Saul answered, "Am I not a Benjamite, from the smallest of the tribes

of Israel? And is not my family the least of all the families of the tribe of Benjamin? Why then do you say such a thing to me?"
22 Samuel took Saul and his servant, led them into the hall, and gave them a place at the head of those who had been invited, about thirty men.[l] 23 Samuel said to the cook, "Bring the portion I gave you, the one I told you to set aside." 24 The cook lifted the thigh and what was on it[m] and put it down before Saul. Samuel said, "Here is the portion that was reserved. Put it in front of you and eat, because it was kept for you for this appointed time, from when I said, 'I have invited the people.'"[n] So Saul ate with Samuel that day.
25 After they came down from the high place into the town, he talked with Saul on the roof.[o] 26 They rose early, and at daybreak Samuel called to Saul on the roof, "Get up, so that I can send you on your way." Saul got up, and the two of them, Saul and Samuel, went out of doors. 27 When they had come down to the far end of the town, Samuel told Saul, "Tell the young man to pass on before us," and he passed on. "But as for you, stand here a while, so that I may let you hear the word of God."

Notes

- a (9:1) Kish probably means "gift" or "bow" (uncertain). The Septuagint spells the names in this genealogy differently (Brenton: Kis, Abiel, Jared, Bachir, Aphec).
- b (9:1) Or "a mighty man of valor." Hebrew gibbor ḥayil can refer to wealth, strength, or social standing.
- c (9:2) Saul (Hebrew Sha'ul) means "asked for" (see 1:20 and 8:10).
- d (9:4) The locations of Shalishah, Shaalim, and Zuph (verse 5) are uncertain.
- e (9:8) Hebrew "a quarter of a shekel of silver," about 3 grams. Coins were not yet in use; the silver would have been weighed.
- f (9:9) Hebrew navi'. Seer is Hebrew ro'eh, "one who sees."
- g (9:12) Hebrew bamah, an elevated place of worship, often on a hill.
- h (9:15) Literally "had uncovered Samuel's ear."
- i (9:16) Hebrew nagid, "leader" or "prince," a title for one designated by God to rule, used here instead of "king."
- j (9:16) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "I have looked upon the humiliation of my people" (Brenton); compare Exodus 3:7.
- k (9:17) Or "will rule." The Hebrew verb usually means "restrain."
- l (9:22) The Septuagint reads "about seventy men" (Brenton).
- m (9:24) Or "the thigh and the fat tail." The Hebrew is uncertain.

- n (9:24) Hebrew uncertain; literally "for at the appointed time it was kept for you, saying, 'I have invited the people.'" The Septuagint reads, "for it is set before you as a testimony in preference to the others; take of it" (Brenton, modernized).
- o (9:25) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads, "and they prepared a lodging for Saul on the roof, and he lay down" (Brenton). Roofs were flat and used as living space.

Chapter 10

1 Samuel took a flask of oil, poured it over Saul's head, kissed him,
and said, "Has Yahweh not anointed you ruler over his inheritance?
[a] 2 When you depart from me today, you will find two men by
Rachel's tomb on the border of Benjamin, at Zelzah.[b] They will tell
you, 'The donkeys you set out to seek are found. Now your father
has dropped the matter of the donkeys and is anxious about you,
saying, "What shall I do about my son?"' 3 Then you will go on from
there and come to the oak[c] of Tabor. There three men will meet you
on their way up to God at Bethel: one carries three kids, another
three loaves of bread, and another a skin of wine. 4 They will greet
you and give you two loaves of bread, which you are to accept from
their hand. 5 After that you will come to Gibeath-elohim,[d] the place
of the Philistine garrison.[e] When you arrive there at the town, you
will meet a company of prophets coming down from the high place,
with lute, hand drum, pipe, and harp going before them, while they
prophesy. 6 Then the Spirit of Yahweh will rush upon you, and you
will prophesy with them and be changed into another man. 7 When
these signs have come upon you, do what the occasion calls for, for
God is with you. 8 Then go ahead of me to Gilgal.[f] I will come to you
there to present burnt offerings and offer peace offerings. Wait seven
days until I arrive and tell you what to do."
9 When Saul turned to leave Samuel, God changed his heart, and all
those signs happened the same day. 10 When they came there to the
hill, a band of prophets met him, and the Spirit of God rushed upon
him, and he prophesied among them. 11 Everyone who had known
him earlier saw him prophesying with the prophets, and the people
asked each other, "What has happened to the son of Kish? Is Saul one
of the prophets too?" 12 A man from there answered, "And who is their

father?"[g] So it became a proverb: "Is Saul also among the prophets?"
13 When he had finished prophesying, he came to the high place.
14 Saul's uncle asked him and his servant, "Where did you go?" "To search for the donkeys," he said. "When we found that they were missing, we went to Samuel." 15 Saul's uncle said, "Please tell me what Samuel said to you." 16 Saul told his uncle, "He let us know for certain that the donkeys were found." But about the matter of the kingdom, of which Samuel had spoken, he told him nothing.
17 Then Samuel called the people together to Yahweh at Mizpah. 18 He said to the Israelites, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'I brought Israel up out of Egypt, and I rescued you from the hand of the Egyptians and from the hand of all the kingdoms that oppressed you.' 19 But today you have rejected your God, who saves you from all your troubles and distresses. And you have said,[h] 'No! Set a king over us.' Now therefore present yourselves before Yahweh by your tribes and by your thousands."[i]
20 Then Samuel brought all the tribes of Israel near, and the tribe of Benjamin was taken by lot. 21 He brought the tribe of Benjamin near by its families, and the family of the Matrites was taken; and Saul son of Kish was taken.[j] But when they looked for him, he could not be found. 22 So they inquired again of Yahweh, "Has the man come here yet?"[k] And Yahweh said, "There he is, hidden among the baggage."
23 They ran and brought him from there. When he stood among the people, he was taller than any of them from his shoulders up. 24 Samuel said to all the people, "Do you see the one whom Yahweh has chosen? There is no one like him among all the people." And all the people shouted, "Long live the king!"
25 Samuel explained to the people the way the kingship works,[l] wrote it down in a book, and placed it in front of Yahweh. Then Samuel dismissed everyone to go home. 26 Saul also went home to Gibeah, and with him went the warriors[m] whose hearts God had touched. 27 But some worthless men[n] said, "How can this man save us?" They despised him and brought him no gift. But he kept silent.[o] [Nahash king of the Ammonites had been crushing the Gadites and the Reubenites with great cruelty, putting out the right eye of every one

of them and letting no one rescue Israel. Among the Israelites east of the Jordan no man remained whose right eye Nahash king of the Ammonites had not put out, except seven thousand men who escaped from the Ammonites and made their way into Jabesh-gilead.][p]

Notes

- a (10:1) The Septuagint has a longer text: "Has the Lord not anointed you as ruler over his people, over Israel? You will govern the Lord's people and save them from the grip of their enemies; and here is your sign that the Lord has anointed you as ruler over his inheritance" (Brenton, modernized). The traditional Hebrew text has probably lost the middle of the verse by a copying error, the eye of a scribe skipping from one "the Lord has anointed you" to the next.
- b (10:2) Zelzah is otherwise unknown; the Septuagint reads differently (Brenton, "exulting greatly").
- c (10:3) Or "great tree" or "terebinth."
- d (10:5) Gibeath-elohim means "the hill of God." The Septuagint reads "the hill of God" (Brenton).
- e (10:5) Or "a garrison commander" or "a pillar." Hebrew netsib; the Septuagint takes it as a name, "Nasib the Philistine" (Brenton).
- f (10:8) Gilgal means "circle" (of stones), near Jericho (Joshua 4:19–20).
- g (10:12) That is, prophets do not inherit their calling; anyone may receive the Spirit. The Septuagint reads "And who is his father?" (Brenton).
- h (10:19) So many Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint (Brenton, "Nay"). The traditional Hebrew text reads "you said to him," using a word that sounds the same as "no."
- i (10:19) Or "by your clans." The Hebrew word 'eleph, "thousand," can also mean a clan or military unit.
- j (10:21) The Septuagint adds, "and they brought near the family of Matri, man by man" (Brenton has "they bring near the family of Mattari, man by man"), a step that appears to have dropped out of the Hebrew.
- k (10:22) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "Will the man come here?" (Brenton).
- l (10:25) Or "the custom of the kingdom." Hebrew mishpat hammelukah; compare 8:9–11 and Deuteronomy 17:14–20.
- m (10:26) Hebrew "the force" or "the valiant men"; the Septuagint reads "sons of strength," that is, warriors (Brenton has "mighty men").
- n (10:27) Hebrew "sons of Belial."
- o (10:27) So the traditional Hebrew text, literally "and he was like one keeping silent." With a slight change in the Hebrew letters, 4QSam-a and the Septuagint read instead "And about a month later" (Brenton, at the start of 11:1, "And it came to pass about a month after this"), which leads into chapter 11.

- p (10:27) The bracketed paragraph is found in 4QSam-a, a Hebrew manuscript of Samuel from Qumran (first century BC), between 10:27 and 11:1. It is not in the traditional Hebrew text or the Septuagint, but Josephus (Jewish Antiquities, book 6) retells the same events, which suggests that he knew a text that had it. Many scholars think the traditional Hebrew text lost the paragraph by a copying error; others think it was added to explain Nahash's demand in 11:2. The wording here is this translation's own rendering of the reported text; the scroll is damaged in places. This needs scholarly review.

Chapter 11

1 Then Nahash[a] the Ammonite went up and besieged Jabesh-gilead.[b]
All the men of Jabesh said to Nahash, "Make a treaty with us, and
we will serve you." 2 But Nahash the Ammonite told them, "On this
term I will cut a covenant with you, that I put out every right eye of
yours, and so lay disgrace on all Israel." 3 The elders of Jabesh said to
him, "Hold off from us for seven days, and we will send messengers
into every border of Israel. Then, if no one comes to save us, we will
come out to you." 4 When the messengers came to Gibeah of Saul and
told these things in the people's hearing, all the people lifted up their
voices and wept.
5 Now Saul was just then coming from the field after the oxen. Saul
said, "Why are the people weeping?" And they related to him the
words of the men of Jabesh. 6 When Saul heard these words, the Spirit
of God rushed upon him, and his anger burned hot. 7 He took a pair
of oxen, cut them into pieces, and sent the pieces by messengers
across the whole territory of Israel with this word: "Whoever does not
march out behind Saul and Samuel will have this done to his oxen!"
Terror from Yahweh fell on the people, and they came out together
as one. 8 Saul mustered them at Bezek: there were three hundred
thousand men of Israel and thirty thousand men of Judah.[c] 9 They told
the messengers who had come, "Say this to the men of Jabesh-gilead:
'Tomorrow, by the time the sun is hot, you will have rescue.'" When
the messengers came and told the men of Jabesh, they were glad. 10
Then the men of Jabesh said to the Ammonites, "Tomorrow we will
come out to you, and you may deal with us however you please." 11 The
next day Saul arranged the people in three companies. They broke
into the middle of the camp during the morning watch[d] and struck

down the Ammonites until the heat of the day. Those who were left were so scattered that not two of them were left together.
12 Then the people said to Samuel, “Who was it that said, ‘Shall Saul reign over us?’ Hand the men over, and we will put them to death.” 13 But Saul said, “No one will be put to death this day, for today Yahweh has brought rescue to Israel.”
14 Samuel said to the people, “Come, let us go to Gilgal and there renew the kingship.” 15 So all the people went to Gilgal, and there at Gilgal they made Saul king before Yahweh.[e] There they offered peace offerings before Yahweh, and there Saul and all the men of Israel rejoiced greatly.

Notes

- a (11:1) Nahash means “serpent.” On the paragraph that some ancient witnesses place before this verse, see the note at 10:27. In the Septuagint and 4QSam-a (as reported), the verse begins “And about a month later” (Brenton, “And it came to pass about a month after this”).
- b (11:1) Jabesh-gilead was a town east of the Jordan, in Gilead; Jabesh means “dry.” Compare Judges 21:8–14.
- c (11:8) The Septuagint reads “six hundred thousand” and “seventy thousand” (Brenton). The Hebrew word ’eleph, “thousand,” may also mean a military unit, which would make the figures much smaller.
- d (11:11) Hebrew “in the morning watch,” the last of the three watches of the night, from about 2 a.m. until about 6 a.m.
- e (11:15) The Septuagint reads “and Samuel anointed Saul there to be king before the Lord” (Brenton), and it ends the verse, “and Samuel and all Israel rejoiced greatly” (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 12

1 Samuel said to all Israel, “I have listened to your voice in all that you said to me, and I have set a king over you. 2 Now look, the king walks before you. As for me, I am old and gray-headed, and my sons, look, they are with you. I have walked before you from my youth until this day. 3 Here I stand. Bear witness against me in the presence of Yahweh and his anointed. Have I taken anyone’s ox or donkey? Whom have I cheated? Whom have I crushed? From whom have I taken a bribe, that I should shut my eyes with it?[a] Say so, and I will pay it back.” 4 They said, “You have not defrauded us or crushed us,

nor taken anything at all from anyone's hand." 5 He said to them,
"Yahweh is witness against you, and his anointed is witness this day,
that you have not found anything in my hand." And they said,[b] "He
is witness."
6 Samuel said to the people, "Yahweh is witness,[c] who appointed
Moses and Aaron and brought your fathers up from the land of Egypt.
7 Now stand here, and I will argue my case with you before Yahweh
concerning all the righteous deeds that Yahweh did for you and your
fathers. 8 When Jacob went into Egypt,[d] and your fathers cried out to
Yahweh, Yahweh sent Moses and Aaron, who brought your fathers
out of Egypt and settled them in this place. 9 But they forgot Yahweh
their God, and he handed them over to Sisera, the commander of
Hazor's army,[e] to the Philistines, and to the king of Moab, who made
war on them. 10 Then they cried out to Yahweh and said, 'We have
sinned, for we have forsaken Yahweh and served the Baals and the
Ashtoreths. But now rescue us from the hand of our enemies, and we
will serve you.' 11 And Yahweh sent Jerubbaal,[f] Bedan,[g] Jephthah, and
Samuel,[h] and rescued you from the hand of your enemies on every
side, and you lived in security. 12 But when you saw that Nahash king
of the Ammonites was moving against you, you told me, 'No, we want
a king to reign over us,' when Yahweh your God was your king. 13 Now
look, here is the king whom you chose, for whom you asked. See,
Yahweh has set a king over you. 14 If you will fear Yahweh and serve
him and listen to his voice and not rebel against Yahweh's command,
and if both you and the king who reigns over you follow Yahweh your
God, all will be well.[i] 15 But if you will not listen to Yahweh's voice, but
rebel against Yahweh's command, then the hand of Yahweh will be
against you, as it was against your fathers.[j] 16 Now therefore take your
stand and see this great thing that Yahweh will do before your eyes.
17 Is it not wheat harvest today?[k] I will call on Yahweh, and he will
send thunder and rain. Then you will know and see that the wrong
you have done in Yahweh's sight is great, in asking for yourselves a
king." 18 So Samuel called on Yahweh, and Yahweh sent thunder and
rain that day, and all the people greatly feared Yahweh and Samuel.

19 All the people said to Samuel, “Pray for your servants to Yahweh
your God, that we do not die; for we have added to all our sins this
evil of asking for ourselves a king.” 20 Samuel said to the people, “Fear
not. You have indeed done all this evil; only, do not turn away from
following Yahweh, but serve Yahweh with all your heart. 21 Do not
turn aside after empty things,[l] which neither profit nor rescue, for
they are empty. 22 For Yahweh will not abandon his people, for the
sake of his great name, because it has pleased Yahweh to make you
a people for himself. 23 As for me, I would never sin against Yahweh
by giving up praying for you. I will teach you the good and upright
way. 24 Only fear Yahweh and serve him faithfully with all your heart,
for consider what great things he has done for you. 25 But if you keep
on doing evil, you will be swept off, you and your king alike.”

Notes

- a (12:3) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads “a bribe, even a sandal? Testify against me” (Brenton, modernized), and Sirach 46:19 is reported to reflect a similar text.
- b (12:5) So many Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint. The traditional Hebrew text reads “he said.”
- c (12:6) “Is witness” is supplied from the Septuagint (Brenton: “The Lord who appointed Moses and Aaron is witness”); the Hebrew lacks the word.
- d (12:8) The Septuagint adds, “and his sons, and Egypt humbled them” (Brenton, modernized).
- e (12:9) The Septuagint reads “Sisera, commander of the army of Jabin king of Hazor” (Brenton has “Sisara captain of the host of Jabis king of Asor”).
- f (12:11) Jerubbaal is another name for Gideon (Judges 6:32).
- g (12:11) So the traditional Hebrew text; Bedan is not named in Judges. The Septuagint reads “Barak” (Brenton, “Barac”), which fits Judges 4–5.
- h (12:11) So the traditional Hebrew text. Some ancient witnesses, including the Syriac, are reported to read “Samson.”
- i (12:14) “All will be well” is supplied; the Hebrew sentence breaks off after “your God.”
- j (12:15) Literally “against you and against your fathers,” as in the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads “against you and against your king” (Brenton, “upon you and upon your king”).
- k (12:17) The wheat harvest came in May–June, the dry season, when rain was very rare.
- l (12:21) Hebrew tohu, “emptiness,” the word used in Genesis 1:2 (“formless”).

Chapter 13

1 Saul was [...] years old when he became king, and he reigned [...]
two years over Israel.[a]
2 Saul chose for himself three thousand men of Israel. Two thousand
were with Saul at Michmash[b] and in the hill country of Bethel, and
a thousand were with Jonathan[c] at Gibeah of Benjamin. The rest of
the people he sent away, each to his tent. 3 Jonathan struck down
the Philistine garrison[d] at Geba, and the Philistines heard of it. Then
Saul had the ram's horn blown throughout the land, saying, "Let the
Hebrews hear!"[e] 4 And all Israel heard the news: "Saul has struck
down the Philistine garrison, and Israel has also become a stench to
the Philistines." And the people were called out after Saul to Gilgal.
5 The Philistines gathered to fight with Israel: thirty thousand chari-
ots,[f] six thousand horsemen, and people as many as the sand on the
shore of the sea. They came up and camped at Michmash, east of
Beth-aven.[g] 6 The men of Israel saw they were in trouble, for the army
was under heavy pressure, and they hid in caves, thickets, rocks,
pits,[h] and cisterns. 7 Some Hebrews even crossed the Jordan to the
land of Gad and Gilead. But Saul was still at Gilgal, and all the people
followed him trembling.
8 He waited seven days, the time set by Samuel, but Samuel did not
come to Gilgal, and the people began to scatter from him. 9 So Saul
said, "Bring the burnt offering and the peace offerings here to me."
And he offered the burnt offering. 10 Just as he finished offering the
burnt offering, there was Samuel coming. Saul went out to meet him
and to greet him.[i] 11 "What did you do?" Samuel asked. Saul replied,
"I saw the people slipping away from me, you had not come by the
appointed day, and the Philistines were massing at Michmash, 12 so I
said to myself, 'The Philistines will now march down against me at
Gilgal, and I have not yet sought Yahweh's favor.' So I made myself
offer the burnt offering." 13 "You have behaved foolishly," Samuel told
Saul. "You did not obey the command Yahweh your God gave you.
Otherwise Yahweh would have established your rule over Israel for
all time. 14 But now your kingdom will not last. Yahweh has sought
out for himself a man after his own heart, and Yahweh has appointed

him leader over his people, because you have not kept what Yahweh commanded you."
15 Then Samuel arose and went up from Gilgal to Gibeah of Benjamin.[j]
Saul counted the people who were present with him, about six hundred men. 16 Saul and Jonathan his son, and the people found with them, stayed in Geba of Benjamin, and the Philistines were encamped in Michmash. 17 Raiders came out of the camp of the Philistines in three companies. One company turned toward the road to Ophrah, to the land of Shual; 18 another company turned toward the road to Beth-horon; and another company turned toward the border road that looks down on the Valley of Zeboim,[k] toward the wilderness.
19 Now no blacksmith could be found in all the land of Israel, for the Philistines had said, "Otherwise the Hebrews will make themselves swords or spears." 20 So every Israelite went down to the Philistines to have his plowshare, mattock, axe, or sickle sharpened.[l] 21 The charge was about a quarter of an ounce of silver[m] for the plowshares and the mattocks, and about an eighth of an ounce[n] for the forks and the axes and for setting the goads. 22 So on the day of battle not one of the people with Saul and Jonathan carried a sword or spear; only Saul and his son Jonathan did.
23 And the Philistine garrison went out to the pass of Michmash.

Notes

- a (13:1) The Hebrew text of this verse is incomplete. It reads literally, "Saul was a year old when he became king, and he reigned two years over Israel." A number has evidently been lost before "year," and probably before "two years" as well. The verse is absent from the Septuagint (Brenton). Acts 13:21 gives Saul's reign as forty years, and Josephus is reported to give twenty or forty years in different passages; some later Greek manuscripts are reported to read "thirty years old." The bracketed gaps mark the missing numbers. This needs scholarly review.
- b (13:2) Michmash was a town about 7 miles (11 kilometers) northeast of Jerusalem.
- c (13:2) Jonathan means "Yahweh has given."
- d (13:3) Or "the garrison commander" or "the Philistine pillar." Hebrew netsib; the Septuagint reads "Nasib the Philistine" (Brenton). Likewise in verse 4.
- e (13:3) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "The slaves have revolted" (Brenton, "The servants have despised us"), taking the Hebrew letters differently.

- f (13:5) So the traditional Hebrew text and the Septuagint (Brenton). Some Greek manuscripts and the Syriac are reported to read “three thousand,” which may be original.
- g (13:5) Beth-aven means “house of wickedness,” possibly a mocking name for Bethel (“house of God”); compare Hosea 4:15.
- h (13:6) Or “in tombs” or “in strongholds.” The Hebrew word is rare.
- i (13:10) Literally “to bless him.”
- j (13:15) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint has a longer text: “and departed from Gilgal, and the rest of the people went up after Saul to meet the men of war, when they had come out of Gilgal to Gibeah of Benjamin” (Brenton, modernized and slightly simplified). The Hebrew may have lost words by a copying error.
- k (13:18) Zeboim means “hyenas.”
- l (13:20) So the Septuagint (Brenton, “sickle”). The Hebrew repeats the word for “plowshare.”
- m (13:21) Hebrew pim, a weight found in excavations, about two-thirds of a shekel, about 8 grams. The meaning of this verse was unknown until such weights were found; the Septuagint reads “three shekels” (Brenton).
- n (13:21) Hebrew “a third of a shekel,” about 4 grams.

Chapter 14

1 One day Jonathan son of Saul said to the young man carrying his armor, “Come, let us go across to the Philistine outpost over on that side.” But he did not tell his father. 2 Saul was staying at the outskirts of Gibeah under the pomegranate tree at Migron, and the people with him were about six hundred men. 3 Ahijah[a] son of Ahitub, brother of Ichabod, son of Phinehas, son of Eli, the priest of Yahweh at Shiloh, wore the ephod.[b] The people did not know Jonathan had left. 4 On each side of the pass through which Jonathan intended to reach the Philistine outpost stood a rocky cliff. One was named Bozez, and the other Seneh.[c] 5 The one crag rose on the north in front of Michmash, and the other on the south in front of Geba.

6 Jonathan told the young man who bore his armor, “Come on, let us cross over to the outpost of these uncircumcised men. Perhaps Yahweh will work on our behalf, for nothing keeps Yahweh from giving victory, whether through many or through few.” 7 His armor-bearer answered, “Do whatever you have in mind. Go ahead; I am with you, heart and soul.”[d] 8 Then Jonathan said, “Look, we will cross

over to the men and let them see us. 9 If they say to us, 'Stand still
until we reach you,' then we will stand where we are and not go up
to them. 10 But if they say, 'Come up to us,' then we will go up, for
Yahweh has given them into our hand. This will be the sign to us."
11 The two of them let the Philistine outpost see them. "Look," said
the Philistines, "the Hebrews are coming out of the holes they were
hiding in." 12 The men of the garrison called out to Jonathan and his
armor-bearer, "Climb up to us, and we will let you know something!"
Jonathan told his armor-bearer, "Climb up after me, for Yahweh has
delivered them into Israel's hands." 13 Then Jonathan climbed up on
his hands and feet, and his armor-bearer after him. They fell before
Jonathan, and his armor-bearer finished them off behind him. 14 In that
first attack Jonathan and his armor-bearer killed about twenty men,
in an area of roughly half an acre.[e] 15 Terror spread through the camp,
in the field, and among all the people. The garrison and the raiders
also trembled. The earth quaked, and it became a terror from God.[f]
16 Saul's lookouts in Gibeah of Benjamin looked, and there was the
crowd, melting away and running here and there.[g] 17 Then Saul said
to the people who were with him, "Count now and see who has gone
from us." When they had counted, Jonathan and his armor-bearer
were not there. 18 Saul told Ahijah, "Bring near the ark of God."[h] For
the ark of God was with the Israelites at that time. 19 While Saul was
talking to the priest, the uproar in the camp of the Philistines kept
growing louder and louder. So Saul said to the priest, "Withdraw your
hand." 20 Then Saul and all the people with him were called together,
and they went into the battle. And there was every man's sword
against his fellow, in very great confusion. 21 The Hebrews who had
been with the Philistines before, who had gone up with them into the
camp, also turned[i] to be with the Israelites who were with Saul and
Jonathan. 22 Likewise all the men of Israel who had hidden themselves
in the hill country of Ephraim heard that the Philistines had fled, and
they too pursued hard after them in the battle. 23 So Yahweh saved
Israel that day, and the battle passed beyond Beth-aven.[j]
24 The men of Israel were hard pressed that day, for Saul had bound the
people under an oath, saying, "Cursed is the man who eats any food

before evening, until I have taken vengeance on my enemies."[k] So none of the people tasted food. 25 All the people[l] came into the forest, and there was honey on the ground. 26 When the people entered the forest, there was the honey dripping, but no one put his hand to his mouth, for the people feared the oath. 27 But Jonathan had not heard when his father bound the people with the oath. So he reached out the tip of the staff that was in his hand and dipped it in the honeycomb and brought his hand to his mouth, and his eyes brightened.[m] 28 Then one of the people said, "Your father strictly bound the people with an oath, saying, 'Cursed is the man who eats food today.'" And the people were faint. 29 Jonathan said, "My father has brought trouble on the land. See how my eyes have brightened because I tasted a little of this honey. 30 How much better it would have been if the people had eaten today without restraint from the spoil of their enemies! As it is, the Philistines have not suffered a great defeat."

31 They struck down the Philistines that day from Michmash to Aijalon, and the people were very faint. 32 The people rushed greedily on the plunder. They took sheep and cattle and calves, slaughtered them on the ground, and the people ate them with the blood. 33 Then they told Saul, "Look, the people are sinning against Yahweh by eating with the blood." He said, "You have dealt faithlessly. Roll a large stone to me here today."[n] 34 Saul said, "Spread out among the troops and tell them: 'Every man is to bring me his ox, and every man his sheep. Butcher them on this stone and then eat, and do not sin against Yahweh by eating meat that still has blood in it.'" That night every one of them led his ox there and butchered it. 35 Saul built an altar to Yahweh; this was the first altar that he built to Yahweh.

36 Saul said, "Let us go down after the Philistines in the night and plunder them until daylight, and leave not one of them alive." "Do whatever you think best," they said. But the priest said, "Let us approach God here first." 37 So Saul asked counsel of God, "Shall I go down after the Philistines? Will you give them into the hand of Israel?" But he did not answer him that day. 38 Saul said, "Draw near here, all the leaders[o] of the people; learn and see in what way this sin has happened today. 39 As Yahweh lives, who gives Israel victory, even

if the guilt is in my son Jonathan, he must die." Yet no one among all the people answered him. 40 Then he said to all Israel, "You be on one side, and I and my son Jonathan will be on the other side." The people said to Saul, "Do what seems good to you." 41 Therefore Saul said to Yahweh, the God of Israel, "Give Thummim."[p] And Jonathan and Saul were taken by lot, and the people went free. 42 Saul said, "Cast lots between me and Jonathan my son." And Jonathan was taken.[q]
43 Saul said to Jonathan, "Tell me what you have done." Jonathan told him, "I did indeed taste a little honey with the end of the rod in my hand. Here I am; I must die." 44 Saul said, "May God do so, and more also; you shall surely die, Jonathan." 45 The people said to Saul, "Must Jonathan die, when he has won this great victory for Israel? Never! As Yahweh lives, not a hair of his head will fall to the ground, for what he did today he did with God's help." So the people rescued Jonathan from death. 46 Then Saul went up from pursuing the Philistines, and the Philistines went to their own place.
47 When Saul had taken the kingship over Israel, he made war all around against all his enemies: Moab, the Ammonites, Edom, the kings of Zobah, and the Philistines. Wherever he turned, he inflicted punishment.[r] 48 He acted valiantly and struck down the Amalekites, and rescued Israel from the hand of those who plundered them.
49 Saul's sons were Jonathan, Ishvi,[s] and Malchi-shua.[t] His two daughters were named Merab, the older, and Michal, the younger.[u] 50 The name of Saul's wife was Ahinoam,[v] daughter of Ahimaaz. His army's commander was named Abner,[w] son of Ner, Saul's uncle. 51 Kish was the father of Saul, and Ner the father of Abner was the son of Abiel.
52 There was fierce war against the Philistines all the days of Saul. Whenever Saul saw any mighty man or any valiant man, he took him into his service.

Notes

- a (14:3) Ahijah means "brother of Yahweh" or "Yahweh is my brother."
- b (14:3) The ephod here is a priestly garment used in seeking God's answer (compare 23:9–12).
- c (14:4) Bozez perhaps means "shining" and Seneh "thorny" (both uncertain).
- d (14:7) So the traditional Hebrew text, literally "Turn; here I am with you as your heart." The Septuagint reads "my heart is as your heart" (Brenton, modernized).

- e (14:14) Hebrew "in about half a furrow of a yoke of field," probably half the area that a pair of oxen could plow in a day. The phrase is obscure; the Septuagint reads differently, "with darts and slings and stones of the field" (Brenton, modernized). This needs scholarly review.
- f (14:15) Or "a very great terror."
- g (14:16) So the traditional Hebrew text, literally "and it went and hither." The Septuagint reads "thrown into confusion on every side" (Brenton, modernized).
- h (14:18) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads, "Bring the ephod, for he wore the ephod at that time before Israel" (Brenton, modernized), which agrees with verse 3 and with verse 19.
- i (14:21) So the Septuagint and other ancient witnesses. The Hebrew reads "who had gone up with them into the camp all around, they also."
- j (14:23) The Septuagint adds, "and all the people with Saul were about ten thousand men, and the fighting spread through every city of the hill country of Ephraim" (Brenton, modernized and condensed).
- k (14:24) The Septuagint begins the verse, "And Saul committed a great error of ignorance in that day" (Brenton, modernized).
- l (14:25) Hebrew "all the land." The Hebrew of verses 25–26 is difficult.
- m (14:27) So the ketiv (written text); the qere (traditional reading) is "his eyes saw clearly."
- n (14:33) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "Out of Gittaim roll a great stone to me here" (Brenton, modernized).
- o (14:38) Hebrew "cornerstones," a picture of leaders.
- p (14:41) So the traditional Hebrew text, literally "Give perfect," where the Hebrew word may be read as Thummim. The Septuagint has a longer text, reading in Greek "why have you not answered your servant this day? Is the guilt in me or in my son Jonathan? Lord God of Israel, give clear signs; and if the lot should declare this, give to your people Israel, give holiness" (Brenton, modernized). Many scholars think the Greek reflects a Hebrew text that read, "If this guilt is in me or in my son Jonathan, give Urim; but if it is in your people Israel, give Thummim," and that the traditional text lost words by a copying error. Urim and Thummim were the sacred lots (Exodus 28:30). This needs scholarly review.
- q (14:42) The Septuagint adds, "whomever the Lord shall take by lot, let him die. And the people said to Saul, This thing is not to be done. And Saul prevailed against the people" (Brenton, modernized).
- r (14:47) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "he was victorious" (Brenton), from a Hebrew word with similar letters.
- s (14:49) The Septuagint reads "Jessiu" (Brenton). Ishvi may be another name for Abinadab (31:2; 1 Chronicles 8:33) or for Ish-bosheth (2 Samuel 2:8). Ishvi perhaps means "man of Yahweh" (uncertain).
- t (14:49) Malchi-shua means "my king is salvation" or "king of wealth" (uncertain).

- u (14:49) Merab perhaps means “increase”; Michal perhaps means “who is like God?” (both uncertain).
- v (14:50) Ahinoam means “my brother is pleasantness.”
- w (14:50) Abner means “my father is a lamp.”

Chapter 15

1 Samuel said to Saul, “It was I whom Yahweh sent to anoint you king
over his people, over Israel. Now therefore listen to the sound of the
words of Yahweh. 2 This is what Yahweh of Armies says: ‘I will punish
what Amalek did to Israel, how he set himself against him on the way
when he came up out of Egypt.[a] 3 Now go and attack Amalek, and set
apart for destruction[b] everything he owns. Show him no mercy; spare
nothing, but put to death man and woman alike, child and nursing
infant, ox and sheep, camel and donkey.’”
4 So Saul summoned the people and mustered them at Telaim:[c] two
hundred thousand on foot, and ten thousand from Judah.[d] 5 Saul came
as far as the city of Amalek and set an ambush in the ravine. 6 Saul
told the Kenites, “Go away! Leave the Amalekites, or I will destroy
you along with them, since you were kind to all the Israelites when
they came up from Egypt.” So the Kenites moved away from the
Amalekites. 7 Saul defeated the Amalekites all the way from Havilah
to Shur, east of Egypt. 8 He took Agag[e] king of the Amalekites alive,
and devoted all the people to destruction with the edge of the sword. 9
But Saul and the people spared Agag, and the best of the sheep and of
the cattle, the fat animals[f] and the lambs, and all that was good, and
were not willing to destroy them. But everything that was despised
and worthless, that they destroyed.
10 Then the word of Yahweh came to Samuel: 11 “I regret that I made
Saul king, for he has turned back from following me and has not car-
ried out my words.” Samuel was angry,[g] and he cried out to Yahweh
all night. 12 Samuel rose early to meet Saul in the morning. Samuel
was told, “Saul came to Carmel,[h] and there he set up a monument
for himself; then he turned and passed on and went down to Gilgal.”[i]
13 When Samuel came to Saul, Saul said to him, “Blessed are you by
Yahweh! I have carried out the word of Yahweh.” 14 Samuel said, “Then
what is this bleating of sheep in my ears, and the lowing of cattle that

I hear?” 15 Saul said, “They brought them from the Amalekites, for the
people spared the best of the sheep and of the cattle to sacrifice to
Yahweh your God; the rest we have devoted to destruction.” 16 Then
Samuel said to Saul, “Stop! Let me tell you what Yahweh said to me
this night.” He said to him, “Speak.”
17 Samuel said, “Though you were small in your own eyes, were you
not made head of the tribes of Israel? Yahweh anointed you king over
Israel. 18 And Yahweh sent you on a journey and said, ‘Go, devote
the sinners, the Amalekites, to destruction, and fight against them
until they are wiped out.’ 19 Why then did you not obey the voice of
Yahweh? Why did you swoop down on the plunder and do what was
evil in Yahweh’s sight?” 20 Saul said to Samuel, “But I did obey the
voice of Yahweh. I went on the mission on which Yahweh sent me. I
brought back Agag king of Amalek, and I devoted the Amalekites to
destruction. 21 But the people took from the plunder sheep and cattle,
the best of what was devoted, to sacrifice to Yahweh your God in
Gilgal.” 22 Samuel replied, “Is Yahweh as pleased with burnt offerings
and sacrifices as he is with obedience to Yahweh’s voice? See, obeying
is better than sacrifice, and listening is better than the fat of rams. 23
Rebellion is as bad as the sin of divination, and stubbornness is like
wickedness and idolatry.[j] Since you have rejected Yahweh’s word, he
has rejected you as king.”
24 Saul said to Samuel, “I have sinned, for I have transgressed the
command of Yahweh and your words, because I feared the people
and listened to their voice. 25 Now therefore, please forgive my sin
and return with me, so that I may bow in worship before Yahweh.” 26
Samuel said to Saul, “I will not return with you, for you have rejected
the word of Yahweh, and Yahweh has rejected you from being king
over Israel.” 27 As Samuel turned to go away, Saul[k] seized the hem of his
robe, and it tore. 28 Samuel said to him, “Yahweh has torn the kingdom
of Israel from you this day and has given it to a neighbor of yours,
who is better than you. 29 Moreover, the Glory[l] of Israel does not lie
or change his mind, since he is not a human being who changes his
mind.” 30 Saul said, “I have sinned. But please honor me now in front
of the elders of my people and in front of Israel. Come back with me,

so that I may worship Yahweh your God." 31 So Samuel turned back after Saul, and Saul bowed in worship before Yahweh.
32 Samuel then said, "Bring me Agag, king of the Amalekites." Agag came to him in chains,[m] saying to himself, "Surely the bitterness of death has passed."[n] 33 Samuel said, "As your sword has made women childless, so your mother will be childless among women." And Samuel hewed Agag in pieces before Yahweh in Gilgal.
34 Then Samuel went to Ramah, and Saul went up to his house at Gibeah of Saul. 35 Samuel did not see Saul again until the day of his death, but Samuel mourned over Saul. And Yahweh regretted that he had made Saul king over Israel.

Notes

- a (15:2) See Exodus 17:8–16 and Deuteronomy 25:17–19.
- b (15:3) Hebrew ḥerem, the giving over of people and goods to God by total destruction. Likewise throughout this chapter.
- c (15:4) Telaim ("lambs") is perhaps the Telem of Joshua 15:24. The Septuagint reads "Gilgal" (Brenton, "Galgala").
- d (15:4) The Septuagint reads "four hundred thousand" and "thirty thousand" (Brenton). On "thousand," see the note at 11:8.
- e (15:8) Agag is perhaps a royal title of the Amalekite kings (compare Numbers 24:7); its meaning is uncertain.
- f (15:9) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; it may mean "the second-born" or "the fattened."
- g (15:11) Or "was distressed."
- h (15:12) This Carmel is a town in the hill country of Judah, south of Hebron (compare 25:2), not Mount Carmel.
- i (15:12) The Septuagint adds that when Samuel came to Gilgal, Saul was offering a burnt offering to the Lord from the best of the plunder taken from Amalek (Brenton).
- j (15:23) Hebrew teraphim. The Hebrew of this line is difficult. The Septuagint reads differently: "idols bring on pain and grief" (Brenton).
- k (15:27) So the Septuagint (Brenton) and 4QSam-a (reported). The Hebrew lacks "Saul."
- l (15:29) Or "the Eternal One" or "the Splendor." Hebrew netsaḥ.
- m (15:32) Or "cheerfully" or "haltingly." The Hebrew word is uncertain; the Septuagint reads "trembling" (Brenton).
- n (15:32) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads, "Is death thus bitter?" (Brenton); the shorter Greek may reflect a Hebrew text reported to read "Surely death is bitter."

Chapter 16

1 Yahweh said to Samuel, "How long will you grieve over Saul, since I
have rejected him as king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil and set
out. I am sending you to Jesse[a] of Bethlehem, because I have chosen a
king for myself from among his sons." 2 "How can I go?" Samuel asked.
"Saul will hear of it and kill me." Yahweh answered, "Take a heifer
with you, and say, 'I have come to offer a sacrifice to Yahweh.' 3 Invite
Jesse to the sacrifice, and then I will show you the course you are to
take; you shall anoint for me whomever I name to you." 4 Samuel did
as Yahweh said and went to Bethlehem.[b] The town elders met him,
trembling, and asked, "Do you come in peace?"[c] 5 "In peace," he said.
"I have come to sacrifice to Yahweh. Consecrate yourselves and come
with me to the sacrifice." And he consecrated Jesse and Jesse's sons,
and he called them to the sacrifice as well.
6 When they came, he looked at Eliab[d] and thought, "Surely Yahweh's
anointed stands before him." 7 But Yahweh told Samuel, "Pay no
regard to how he looks or to how tall he stands, because I have
rejected him. For it is not as man sees:[e] man looks at the eyes,[f] but
Yahweh looks at the heart." 8 Then Jesse called Abinadab[g] and made
him pass before Samuel. He said, "Neither has Yahweh chosen this
one." 9 Then Jesse made Shammah[h] pass by. And he said, "Neither has
Yahweh chosen this one." 10 Jesse made seven of his sons pass before
Samuel. And Samuel said to Jesse, "Yahweh has not chosen these." 11
Then Samuel said to Jesse, "Are these all the young men?" He said,
"There is still the youngest, but he is keeping the sheep." Samuel said
to Jesse, "Send and fetch him, for we will not sit down to eat[i] until
he comes here." 12 So he sent and brought him in. He was ruddy, with
beautiful eyes and a fine appearance. Yahweh said, "Arise, anoint
him, for this is he." 13 Then Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed
him in the midst of his brothers. And the Spirit of Yahweh rushed
upon David[j] from that day forward. Then Samuel rose up and went
to Ramah.
14 Now the Spirit of Yahweh departed from Saul, and an evil spirit from
Yahweh tormented him.[k] 15 Saul's servants said to him, "Look now,
an evil spirit from God is tormenting you. 16 Let our lord command

the servants standing before you to find a man who is a skilled lyre player. Whenever the evil spirit from God is on you, he will play, and it will go well with you." 17 So Saul told his servants, "Look out for me a man who can play well, and bring him to me." 18 One of the young men answered, "Look, I have seen a son of Jesse the Bethlehemite who is skilled in playing, a valiant man, a man of war, wise in speech, a man of good presence; and Yahweh is with him." 19 So Saul sent messengers to Jesse and said, "Send me David your son, who is with the sheep." 20 Jesse took a donkey loaded with bread,[l] a skin of wine, and a young goat, and sent them to Saul by his son David. 21 So David came to Saul and stood before him. Saul came to love him very much, and he became his armor-bearer. 22 Saul sent to Jesse, saying, "Let David stand before me, for he has found favor in my eyes." 23 And whenever the spirit from God was on Saul, David took the lyre in hand and played, and Saul was refreshed and felt well, and the evil spirit left him.

Notes

- a (16:1) Jesse perhaps means "Yahweh exists" or "man" (uncertain).
- b (16:4) Bethlehem means "house of bread."
- c (16:4) Or "Do you come in peace?" The Septuagint adds "you seer" (Brenton).
- d (16:6) Eliab means "my God is father."
- e (16:7) The Hebrew is brief, literally "for not what man sees." The Septuagint reads "for God sees not as a man looks" (Brenton).
- f (16:7) That is, at outward appearance.
- g (16:8) Abinadab means "my father is generous."
- h (16:9) Shammah is perhaps a short form of a name meaning "Yahweh has heard" (uncertain). He is called Shimeah in 2 Samuel 13:3 and Shimea in 1 Chronicles 2:13.
- i (16:11) So the Septuagint. The Hebrew reads "will not turn around" or "sit around," probably at the meal.
- j (16:13) David perhaps means "beloved" (uncertain). This is the first time David is named.
- k (16:14) Or "terrified him."
- l (16:20) Hebrew ḥamor, "donkey," which can also be read ḥomer, a dry measure of about 6 bushels (220 liters). The Septuagint reads "a homer of bread" (Brenton), but a donkey loaded with bread is the more likely meaning.

Chapter 17

1 The Philistines gathered their armies for war. They were gathered
at Socoh,[a] which belongs to Judah, and they encamped at Ephes-
dammim,[b] between Socoh and Azekah. 2 Saul and the Israelites
assembled and camped in the Valley of Elah,[c] and lined up in battle
formation facing the Philistines. 3 The Philistines stood on the moun-
tain on the one side, and Israel stood on the mountain on the other
side, with the valley between them.
4 Then a champion[d] came out from the camp of the Philistines, whose
name was Goliath,[e] of Gath. His height was about nine feet nine
inches.[f] 5 He had a bronze helmet on his head, and he wore a coat of
scale armor; the weight of the coat was about a hundred and twenty-
five pounds[g] of bronze. 6 Bronze greaves were on his legs, and a bronze
javelin[h] was slung between his shoulders. 7 The shaft of his spear was
like a weaver's beam, and the head of his spear weighed about fifteen
pounds[i] of iron. And the shield-bearer went before him. 8 He stood up
and called out to the lines of Israel, "What is this, coming out to set
the battle in order? Am I not the Philistine, and you Saul's servants?
Pick out a man for yourselves, and let him come down to me. 9 If he is
able to fight with me and kill me, then we will be your servants. But
if I prevail against him and kill him, then you shall be our servants
and serve us." 10 And the Philistine said, "I defy the ranks of Israel this
day. Give me a man, and let us fight together." 11 When Saul and all
Israel heard these words of the Philistine, they were shattered and
very much afraid.
12 David was the son of an Ephrathite[j] from Bethlehem in Judah named
Jesse, who had eight sons. In Saul's time Jesse was already an old
man, well along in years.[k] 13 The three oldest sons of Jesse had gone
after Saul to the war. The names of his three sons who went to the
war were Eliab the firstborn, and next to him Abinadab, and the third
Shammah. 14 David was the youngest. The three oldest followed Saul,
15 but David would go back and forth from Saul to tend his father's
sheep at Bethlehem. 16 Forty days the Philistine drew near, early and
late, and presented himself.

17 Jesse said to David his son, “Take now for your brothers about
three-fifths of a bushel[l] of this roasted grain and these ten loaves, and
run with them to the camp to your brothers. 18 And bring these ten
slices of cheese[m] to the commander of their thousand. See how your
brothers are faring, and bring back some token from them.[n] 19 Saul
and they and all the men of Israel are in the Valley of Elah, fighting
with the Philistines.”
20 David got up early the next morning, left the flock with a shepherd,
loaded up, and went as Jesse had told him. He reached the camp[o]
as the army was marching out to its battle position and raising the
war cry. 21 Israel and the Philistines drew up, line facing line. 22 David
left his baggage in the care of the keeper of the baggage and ran to
the battle line. He came and asked his brothers how they were. 23 As
he was talking with them, there was the champion, the Philistine of
Gath named Goliath, coming up out of the ranks of the Philistines.
He spoke the same words as before, and David heard them. 24 All the
men of Israel, when they saw the man, fled from him and were greatly
afraid. 25 The Israelites said, “Do you see this man coming up? He
comes to taunt Israel. The king will give great riches to whoever kills
him, and will give him his daughter and exempt his father’s family[p]
from taxes in Israel.”
26 David asked the men who stood near him, “What will be done for
the man who kills this Philistine and takes away Israel’s shame? Who
is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he dares to defy the armies of
the living God?” 27 The people answered him with the same words:
“So it will be done for the man who kills him.”
28 Eliab his oldest brother heard when he spoke to the men, and Eliab’s
anger burned against David. He said, “Why have you come down?
With whom did you leave those few sheep in the wilderness? I know
your arrogance and the wickedness of your heart; you came down to
watch the battle.” 29 David said, “What have I done now? Was it not
only a word?” 30 Then he turned away from him to another man and
spoke the same way, and the men answered him just as the others
had. 31 The words that David spoke were overheard and told before
Saul, and he had him brought.[q]

32 David told Saul, “Let no one lose courage on account of him.[r] Your
servant will go and fight this Philistine.” 33 Saul answered David, “You
cannot go out against this Philistine and fight him. You are just a boy,
and he has been a warrior since he was young.” 34 David told Saul,
“Your servant has been a shepherd of his father’s sheep. Whenever a
lion or a bear came and took a lamb from the flock, 35 I went out after
it and struck it and rescued the lamb from its mouth. If it rose against
me, I seized it by its beard,[s] struck it, and killed it. 36 Your servant has
struck down both lion and bear, and this uncircumcised Philistine
shall be as one of them, since he has taunted the ranks of the living
God.”[t] 37 David said, “Yahweh who rescued me from the paw of the
lion and from the paw of the bear will rescue me from the hand of
this Philistine.” Saul said to David, “Go, and Yahweh be with you.”
38 Then Saul dressed David in his own garments, set a bronze helmet
on his head, and dressed him in a coat of mail. 39 David fastened his
sword on over his clothes and tried to walk about, since he had never
tested such gear. He told Saul, “I cannot walk in these; I have never
tested them.” And David took them off. 40 He took his staff in his hand
and chose for himself five smooth stones from the stream bed and put
them into the shepherd’s bag he had, into the pouch. With his sling
in his hand, he drew near to the Philistine.
41 The Philistine, with his shield-bearer walking ahead of him,[u] kept
moving closer to David. 42 When the Philistine looked about and saw
David, he scorned him, for he was but a lad, ruddy and good to look at.
43 The Philistine said to David, “Am I a dog, that you come to me with
sticks?”[v] And the Philistine cursed David by his gods. 44 The Philistine
said to David, “Come to me, and I will give your flesh to the birds
of the sky and to the beasts of the field.” 45 Then David said to the
Philistine, “You come to me with a sword, with a spear, and with a
javelin, but I come to you in the name of Yahweh of Armies, the God
of the ranks of Israel, whom you have defied. 46 This day Yahweh will
shut you up into my hand. I will strike you and take your head from
you, and I will give the corpses[w] of the camp of the Philistines this
day to the birds of the sky and to the wild animals of the earth, so
that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel, 47 and so

that everyone assembled here will know that Yahweh does not give victory with sword and spear; the battle belongs to Yahweh, and he will hand you over to us."
48 As the Philistine started forward to attack David, David ran quickly to the battle line toward him.[x] 49 David reached into his bag, took out a stone, and slung it. It struck the Philistine on the forehead and sank in,[y] and he fell face down on the ground.
50 So David prevailed over the Philistine with a sling and with a stone, and struck down the Philistine and killed him; there was no sword in David's hand.[z] 51 Then David ran and stood over the Philistine, took his sword, drew it out of its sheath, killed him, and cut off his head with it. When the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled. 52 The men of Israel and of Judah rose up with a shout and pursued the Philistines as far as Gai[aa] and to the gates of Ekron. The wounded of the Philistines fell along the road from Shaaraim[ab] as far as Gath and Ekron. 53 The Israelites came back from their hot pursuit of the Philistines and plundered their camp. 54 David took the head of the Philistine and brought it to Jerusalem,[ac] but he put his weapons in his tent.
55 When Saul saw David going out against the Philistine, he said to Abner, the commander of the army, "Abner, whose son is this youth?" Abner said, "As you live, O king, I do not know."[ad] 56 The king said, "Ask whose son the young man is." 57 When David returned from killing the Philistine, Abner took him and brought him before Saul with the head of the Philistine in his hand. 58 Saul said to him, "Whose son are you, young man?" David answered, "The son of your servant Jesse the Bethlehemite."

Notes

- a (17:1) Socoh means "thorny place." The Septuagint text of chapters 17–18 is much shorter than the traditional Hebrew text. The oldest complete Greek manuscript (Codex Vaticanus) lacks about two-fifths of the Hebrew material, including 17:12–31, 17:41, 17:48b, 17:50, 17:55–18:5, and other parts of chapter 18. Brenton's edition prints 17:12–31 (from other Greek manuscripts) but lacks 17:41, 17:50, 17:55–58, 18:1–5, 18:9–11, 18:17–19, and 18:30. Scholars debate whether the shorter Greek text represents an earlier form of the story or a shortening made to remove

tensions with chapter 16 (for example, Saul already knows David in 16:21–23 but asks who he is in 17:55–58). This needs scholarly review.

- b (17:1) Ephes-dammim means "boundary of blood."
- c (17:2) Elah means "terebinth" or "great tree."
- d (17:4) Hebrew "the man of the between," that is, one who fights between two armies in single combat. Likewise in verse 23.
- e (17:4) The meaning of the name Goliath is uncertain.
- f (17:4) Hebrew "six cubits and a span," about 2.9 meters. 4QSam-a (as reported) and the Septuagint (Brenton) read "four cubits and a span," about 6 feet 9 inches (2 meters), which Josephus is also reported to support. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters), and a span about 9 inches. This needs scholarly review.
- g (17:5) Hebrew "5,000 shekels," about 57 kilograms.
- h (17:6) Or "scimitar."
- i (17:7) Hebrew "600 shekels," about 6.9 kilograms.
- j (17:12) Ephrathite means a man from Ephrathah, the district around Bethlehem (Ruth 1:2; Micah 5:2). Brenton prints verses 12–31, but the oldest Greek manuscript lacks them (see the note at verse 1).
- k (17:12) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "passed for an old man among men") and the Syriac (reported). The Hebrew reads "came among men."
- l (17:17) Hebrew "an ephah," about 22 liters.
- m (17:18) Literally "ten cuts of milk," probably cheeses or curds.
- n (17:18) Or "and take their pledge," perhaps a sign that David had delivered the food.
- o (17:20) Or "the circle of wagons."
- p (17:25) That is, free from taxes or forced labor.
- q (17:31) Verses 12–31 are lacking in the oldest Greek manuscript (see the note at verse 1).
- r (17:32) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "Let not the heart of my lord be cast down within him" (Brenton, modernized).
- s (17:35) Or "its jaw." The Septuagint reads "its throat" (Brenton).
- t (17:36) The Septuagint adds, "Shall I not go and strike him, and take away a reproach this day from Israel? For who is this uncircumcised one?" (Brenton, modernized).
- u (17:41) This verse is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript.
- v (17:43) The Septuagint adds, "and stones? And David said, No, but worse than a dog" (Brenton, modernized).
- w (17:46) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "your limbs and the limbs of the army of the Philistines" (Brenton, modernized).
- x (17:48) The second half of the verse ("David hurried … the Philistine") is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton).

- y (17:49) The Septuagint adds “through the helmet” (Brenton, “the stone penetrated through the helmet into his forehead”).
- z (17:50) This verse is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript.
- aa (17:52) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads “Gath” (Brenton, “Geth”), which fits the end of the verse.
- ab (17:52) Shaaraim means “two gates.” The Septuagint reads “the gates” (Brenton).
- ac (17:54) Jerusalem was not yet in Israelite hands (see 2 Samuel 5:6–9). The statement may anticipate a later time.
- ad (17:55) Verses 55–58 and 18:1–5 are lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript (see the note at verse 1).

Chapter 18

1 When David had finished speaking with Saul, Jonathan’s soul
became bound to David’s soul, and Jonathan loved him as he loved
himself.[a] 2 Saul took him that day and would not let him go back to
his father’s house. 3 And Jonathan and David cut a covenant, since he
loved him as his own soul. 4 Jonathan stripped off the robe that was
on him and gave it to David, with his garments, even his sword, his
bow, and his belt. 5 David went out wherever Saul sent him and had
success,[b] and Saul set him over the men of war. It was good in the
eyes of all the people and also in the eyes of Saul’s servants.
6 As they came in, when David came back from the slaughter of the
Philistine, women came out of all the towns of Israel singing and
dancing to meet King Saul, with tambourines, with joy, and with
three-stringed instruments.[c] 7 The women sang to one another as
they made merry: “Saul has struck down his thousands, and David
his ten thousands.” 8 Saul was very angry, and this saying displeased
him. He said, “They have credited David with ten thousands, and me
they have credited with thousands. What more can he have but the
kingdom?”[d] 9 And Saul eyed David from that day on.[e]
10 The next day an evil spirit from God rushed upon Saul, and he raved[f]
inside his house, while David was playing the lyre with his hand, as
he did day by day. Saul had his spear in his hand. 11 And Saul flung the
spear, saying to himself, “I will strike David through, into the wall.”
But twice David turned aside from before him. 12 Saul was afraid of
David, because Yahweh was with him but had departed from Saul.[g]

13 So Saul removed him from his presence and made him commander
of a thousand. He went out and came in before the people. 14 David
had success in all his ways, and Yahweh was with him. 15 When Saul
saw that he was having great success, he stood in awe of him. 16 But
all Israel and Judah loved David, for he went out and came in before
them.
17 Saul said to David, "Here is my older daughter Merab. I will give her
to you as your wife; only be a brave man for me and fight Yahweh's
battles." Saul thought, "I need not lay a hand on him; the Philistines
can deal with him."[h] 18 David said to Saul, "Who am I, and what is my
life, or my father's clan in Israel, that I should be son-in-law to the
king?" 19 But at the time when Merab, Saul's daughter, should have
been given to David, she was given to Adriel[i] the Meholathite as a
wife.
20 Now Michal, Saul's daughter, loved David. They told Saul, and the
matter was right in his eyes. 21 He was thinking, "I will give her to
him so that she will be a trap for him and the Philistines will be
against him." So for the second time Saul told David, "You can become
my son-in-law today."[j] 22 Saul gave orders to his servants: "Talk with
David privately and say, 'See, the king takes pleasure in you, and all
his servants love you. So now, be son-in-law to the king.'" 23 Saul's
servants repeated these words to David. David replied, "Is it a small
thing in your opinion to become the king's son-in-law, when I am
poor and of little standing?" 24 Saul's servants reported to him, "These
are the words David spoke." 25 Then Saul said, "This is what you are
to tell David: 'The king has no wish for a bride-price[k] other than a
hundred foreskins of the Philistines, to take vengeance on the king's
enemies.'" For Saul planned to make David fall by the hand of the
Philistines. 26 When his servants told David these words, the matter
was right in David's eyes, to become the king's son-in-law. Before
the days had expired,[l] 27 David and his men set out and struck down
two hundred Philistines.[m] David delivered their foreskins, and all of
them were counted out for the king, to make David the king's son-
in-law. And Saul married his daughter Michal to him. 28 Saul saw and
knew that Yahweh was with David, and that Michal, Saul's daughter,

loved him.[n] 29 So Saul was still more afraid of David, and Saul became
David's enemy continually.[o]
30 Then the princes of the Philistines went out to war; and whenever
they went out, David prospered more than all Saul's servants, so that
his name became very dear.[p]

Notes

- a (18:1) Verses 1–5 are lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript (see the note at 17:1).
- b (18:5) Or "acted wisely." The Hebrew verb sakal means both. Likewise in verses 14, 15, and 30.
- c (18:6) Hebrew shalishim, perhaps "triangles," "lutes," or "three-stringed instruments" (uncertain). The Septuagint reads "cymbals" (Brenton). The Septuagint lacks "when David returned from striking down the Philistine" and "to meet King Saul," and reads "to meet David" (Brenton).
- d (18:8) The last sentence is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton).
- e (18:9) Verses 9–11 are lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript.
- f (18:10) Hebrew "prophesied," here of uncontrolled, frenzied behavior.
- g (18:12) The Septuagint reads only "And Saul was alarmed on account of David" (Brenton).
- h (18:17) Verses 17–19 are lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript.
- i (18:19) Adriel means "my help is God." Compare 2 Samuel 21:8, where the traditional Hebrew text names Michal instead of Merab.
- j (18:21) The Hebrew phrase translated "a second time" is obscure (literally "by two"). The last sentence is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton).
- k (18:25) Hebrew mohar, the price paid by the groom to the bride's family.
- l (18:26) The last clause ("Before the days had expired") is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton).
- m (18:27) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "a hundred men" (Brenton), agreeing with verse 25 and with 2 Samuel 3:14.
- n (18:28) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "and that all Israel loved him" (Brenton).
- o (18:29) The last clause is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton).
- p (18:30) This verse is lacking in the Septuagint (Brenton) and in the oldest Greek manuscript.

Chapter 19

1 Saul spoke to Jonathan his son and to all his servants about putting
David to death. But Jonathan, Saul's son, delighted greatly in David. 2

Jonathan told David, “My father Saul is trying to have you killed. Be careful tomorrow morning: find a hiding place and stay out of sight.
3 I will go out and stand beside my father in the field where you are, and I will speak about you to my father. If I learn anything, I will tell you.”
4 Jonathan spoke well of David to his father Saul, saying, “The king should not wrong his servant David, who has done you no wrong and whose actions have greatly benefited you. 5 He risked his own life when he killed the Philistine, and Yahweh won a great victory for all Israel. You saw it and were glad. Why would you sin against innocent blood by killing David for no reason?” 6 Saul listened to the voice of Jonathan, and Saul swore, “As Yahweh lives, he shall not be put to death.” 7 So Jonathan called David and told him all this. Then he took David to Saul, and David served him as he had before.
8 War broke out again, and David went out to fight with the Philistines. He struck them down with a great slaughter, and they fled from before him. 9 Then an evil spirit from Yahweh came upon Saul as he sat in his house with his spear in his hand, while David was playing the lyre with his hand. 10 Saul sought to strike David into the wall with the spear, but he slipped aside from before Saul, so that the spear struck into the wall. And David fled and escaped that night.
11 Saul sent messengers to David’s house to keep watch on it and to kill him in the morning. But David’s wife Michal warned him, “If you do not escape tonight, you will be killed tomorrow.” 12 So Michal let David down through the window, and he went away, fled, and escaped. 13 Michal took the household idol,[a] put it in the bed, placed a goat’s-hair net[b] at its head, and covered it with a garment. 14 When Saul sent messengers to take David, she said, “He is sick.” 15 Then Saul sent the messengers to see David, saying, “Bring him up to me in the bed, so that I may put him to death.” 16 When the messengers came in, there was the household idol in the bed, with the net of goats’ hair at its head. 17 Saul demanded of Michal, “Why did you trick me like this and let my enemy go and get away?” Michal told Saul, “He said to me, ‘Let me go or I will kill you.’”

18 David fled and escaped. He came to Samuel at Ramah and described
to him all that Saul had done to him, and he and Samuel went to stay
in Naioth.[c] 19 It was told Saul, "Look, David is at Naioth in Ramah."
20 Saul sent men to seize David. When they saw a band of prophets
prophesying and Samuel standing as their leader, God's Spirit came
over Saul's men, and they too began to prophesy. 21 When it was told
Saul, he sent other messengers, and they also prophesied. Saul sent
messengers again the third time, and they also prophesied. 22 Then
he himself went to Ramah and came to the great cistern that is at
Secu.[d] He asked, "Where are Samuel and David?" And someone said,
"Look, they are at Naioth in Ramah." 23 He went there to Naioth in
Ramah, and the Spirit of God came upon him also, and he went along
prophesying until he came to Naioth in Ramah. 24 He too stripped
off his garments and prophesied before Samuel, and lay naked[e] all
that day and all that night. Therefore they say, "Is Saul also among
the prophets?"

Notes

- a (19:13) Hebrew teraphim, figurines of household gods, here apparently large enough to resemble a man. Likewise in verse 16.
- b (19:13) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "the liver of a goat" (Brenton), from a Hebrew word of similar form.
- c (19:18) Naioth perhaps means "dwellings" or "pasture camps" (uncertain).
- d (19:22) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "the well of the threshing floor that is in Sephi" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (19:24) Or "with only his undergarment." The Hebrew word can mean partly clothed.

Chapter 20

1 David fled from Naioth at Ramah and found Jonathan. "What did
I do?" he said. "What is my fault? What offense have I committed
against your father, that he is hunting for my life?" 2 "Never!"
Jonathan replied. "You will not die. My father does nothing, large or
small, without telling me. Why would he hide this from me? It is not
so." 3 But David swore again and said, "Your father knows well that
I have found favor in your eyes, and he says to himself, 'Jonathan
must not know of this, lest he be grieved.' But truly, as Yahweh

lives and as your soul lives, there is but a step between me and death." 4 Jonathan told David, "I will do whatever you ask." 5 David told Jonathan, "Tomorrow is the new moon,[a] and I am supposed to dine with the king. Let me go, though, and hide in the countryside until the evening of the third day. 6 If your father notices I am gone, say, 'David urgently asked my permission to hurry to his hometown of Bethlehem, because the whole clan is holding its yearly sacrifice there.' 7 Should he say, 'Good,' there is peace for your servant. But should his anger burn hot, be sure that harm has been settled on by him. 8 So treat your servant kindly, since you have made a covenant before Yahweh with your servant. But if I am guilty, you yourself may kill me; why hand me over to your father?" 9 Jonathan said, "Far be that from you! If I knew that harm had been determined by my father to come upon you, would I not tell you?" 10 Then David said to Jonathan, "Who will tell me if your father answers you harshly?"
11 "Come," said Jonathan to David, "let us go out to the countryside." So the two of them went out there. 12 Jonathan said to David, "By Yahweh, the God of Israel![b] When I have sounded out my father about this time tomorrow, or the third day, and see that it is good toward David, will I not then send to you and uncover it in your ear? 13 But if my father has a mind to do you harm, Yahweh do so to Jonathan and more, unless I uncover it to you and send you off, so that you may go in peace. May Yahweh be with you, as he has been with my father. 14 If I am still alive, will you not show me the steadfast love[c] of Yahweh, so that I may not die? 15 and never withdraw your faithful love from my family, not even when Yahweh wipes out every one of David's enemies from the earth." 16 So Jonathan bound himself to David's house, saying, "May Yahweh hold David's enemies accountable."[d] 17 Jonathan again made David swear, because of his love for him; for he loved him with the love of his own soul.
18 Then Jonathan said to him, "Tomorrow is the new moon, and you will be missed, because your seat will be empty. 19 On the third day go down quickly[e] and come to the place where you hid yourself on the day of the deed,[f] and remain beside the stone Ezel.[g] 20 And I will shoot three arrows to one side of it, as if I were shooting at a target.

21 Then I will send a boy to find the arrows. If I tell him plainly, 'The
arrows are on this side of you; get them,' then come, since as Yahweh
lives you are safe and there is no danger. 22 But if I say to the lad, 'See,
the arrows are farther on from you,' then go, for Yahweh has sent
you away. 23 As for the matter of which you and I have spoken, look,
Yahweh is between you and me forever."
24 So David hid himself in the field. When the new moon came, the
king sat down to eat the meal. 25 The king sat on his seat, as at other
times, on the seat by the wall. Jonathan stood up,[h] and Abner sat
by Saul's side, but David's place was empty. 26 Yet Saul did not say
anything that day, for he thought, "Something has happened to him;
he is not clean. Surely he is not clean."[i] 27 On the following day, the
second day of the month, David's seat was empty. Saul said to his son
Jonathan, "How is it that Jesse's son has not come to the meal, either
yesterday or today?" 28 Jonathan answered Saul, "David earnestly
asked leave of me to go to Bethlehem. 29 He said, 'Please let me go,
since our family is holding a sacrifice in the town and my brother has
ordered me to attend. If I have your favor, let me slip away and visit
my brothers.' That is why he has not come to the king's table."
30 Then Saul's anger burned against Jonathan, and he said to him, "You
son of a perverse, rebellious woman![j] Do I not know that you have
chosen the son of Jesse to your own shame, and to the shame of your
mother's nakedness? 31 For all the days the son of Jesse lives on the
ground, you will not be made firm, you or your kingship. Now send
and fetch him to me, for he is a son of death."[k] 32 Jonathan asked his
father Saul, "Why should he be put to death? What has he done?" 33
Saul threw his spear at him to hit him, and Jonathan realized that his
father was set on killing David. 34 Jonathan got up from the table in
burning anger. He ate nothing on that second day of the month, for
he was distressed over David, because his father had humiliated him.
35 In the morning Jonathan went out into the field at the time
appointed with David, and a little boy with him. 36 He said to his
boy, "Run, find the arrows I shoot." As the boy ran, he shot an arrow
beyond him. 37 When the lad reached the spot where the arrow lay that
Jonathan had shot, Jonathan called out after the lad, "Is the arrow not

farther on from you?” 38 Jonathan called after the boy, “Quick! Hurry!
Do not stand still!” So Jonathan’s boy gathered up the arrows and
came to his master. 39 The lad knew nothing of it; only Jonathan and
David knew the matter. 40 Jonathan gave his weapons to his boy and
said to him, “Go, carry them to the town.” 41 When the boy had gone,
David got up from the south side,[l] fell with his face to the ground, and
bowed three times. They kissed each other and wept together, though
David wept more.[m] 42 Then Jonathan told David, “Go with my blessing
of peace, for the two of us have sworn together by Yahweh’s name,
saying, ‘Yahweh is between you and me, between your descendants
and mine, forever.’” David got up and left, and Jonathan returned to
the town.[n]

Notes

- a (20:5) The new moon marked the beginning of each month and was a festival day with special meals and sacrifices (Numbers 10:10; 28:11–15).
- b (20:12) Hebrew “Yahweh, the God of Israel—” The oath formula is incomplete; a verb such as “is witness” may have been lost. This needs scholarly review.
- c (20:14) Hebrew ḥesed, loyal love based on a covenant.
- d (20:16) The Hebrew of verses 14–16 is difficult; “enemies of David” may be a scribal softening of “David” himself (compare 25:22).
- e (20:19) Hebrew uncertain, literally “go down greatly.” The Septuagint reads “you shall stay three days” (Brenton, modernized).
- f (20:19) Or “on the day of the business,” probably referring to the events of 19:2–7.
- g (20:19) So the traditional Hebrew text; Ezel perhaps means “departure.” The Septuagint reads “beside that mound” (Brenton has “by that ergab”).
- h (20:25) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads “and he went before Jonathan” (Brenton); some scholars suggest an original “Jonathan sat opposite.”
- i (20:26) The Septuagint reads “because he has not purified himself” (Brenton) in place of the repeated clause.
- j (20:30) Literally “son of a perverse woman of rebellion,” an insult aimed at Jonathan himself. The Septuagint reads “son of traitorous young women” (Brenton, modernized).
- k (20:31) That is, he must die.
- l (20:41) So the Septuagint (Brenton, “from the argab”), which reflects the mound of verse 19. The Hebrew reads “from beside the south.”
- m (20:41) Hebrew uncertain.
- n (20:42) In Hebrew the last sentence of this verse is 21:1, and 21:1–15 in English is 21:2–16 in Hebrew.

Chapter 21

1 David came to Nob,[a] to Ahimelech[b] the priest. Ahimelech came
trembling to meet David and said to him, "Why are you alone, and
no one with you?" 2 David said to Ahimelech the priest, "The king
has commissioned me with a task. He told me, 'Let nobody learn
anything of the business I am sending you on, or of the orders I have
given you.' I have posted my young men at a certain place.[c] 3 Now,
what is there under your hand? Give five loaves of bread into my
hand, or whatever is to be found." 4 The priest answered David, "There
is no common bread on hand, but there is holy bread, if only the
young men have kept themselves from women." 5 David answered the
priest, "Indeed women have been kept from us, as before whenever I
went out; the vessels[d] of the young men are holy even on a common
journey. All the more today their vessels are holy!"[e] 6 So the priest
gave him holy bread, for there was no bread there except the bread
of the Presence,[f] which is removed from before Yahweh, to put hot
bread in its place on the day it is taken away. 7 Now a certain man of
the servants of Saul was there that day, detained before Yahweh. His
name was Doeg[g] the Edomite,[h] the chief of Saul's herdsmen. 8 David
said to Ahimelech, "Is there not here under your hand a spear or a
sword? I did not even bring my sword or my weapons along, for the
king's errand was urgent." 9 The priest said, "The sword of Goliath the
Philistine, whom you killed in the Valley of Elah, is here, wrapped in
a cloth behind the ephod. Take it if you wish, for there is nothing else
here." David said, "There is none like it. Give it to me."
10 David rose and fled that day from Saul and came to Achish[i] king of
Gath. 11 Achish's servants said to him, "Is this not David, the king of
the land? Is he not the one they sang about as they danced: 'Saul has
killed his thousands, and David his tens of thousands'?" 12 David laid
these words up in his heart and was greatly afraid before Achish, the
king of Gath. 13 So he changed his behavior before them and acted like
a madman in their hands. He made marks[j] on the doors of the gate
and let his spittle run down on his beard. 14 Then Achish said to his
servants, "Look, you see the man is insane. Why have you brought
him to me? 15 Do I lack madmen, that you have brought this fellow

to act the madman in my presence? Shall this fellow come into my house?"

Notes

- a (21:1) In Hebrew, 20:42b is numbered 21:1, and 21:1–15 in English is 21:2–16 in Hebrew. Nob was a town of priests near Jerusalem (22:19).
- b (21:1) Ahimelech means "my brother is king." He is probably the same as Ahijah (14:3). Compare Mark 2:26, which names Abiathar.
- c (21:2) The Hebrew phrase is deliberately vague (compare Ruth 4:1). The Septuagint reads "in the place called, The faithfulness of God, Phellani Maemoni" (Brenton, modernized).
- d (21:5) Or "bodies." The Hebrew word can mean equipment or the body.
- e (21:5) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- f (21:6) Literally "bread of the face," the twelve loaves set before Yahweh in the sanctuary each Sabbath (Leviticus 24:5–9).
- g (21:7) Doeg perhaps means "anxious" (uncertain).
- h (21:7) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "the Syrian" (Brenton), a confusion of the similar Hebrew letters for Edom and Aram. The Septuagint also reads "tending the mules of Saul."
- i (21:10) The meaning of the name Achish is uncertain; it may be Philistine.
- j (21:13) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "drummed upon" (Brenton), from a Hebrew word of similar form.

Chapter 22

1 David left there and escaped to the cave of Adullam.[a] When his brothers and the rest of his father's household heard about it, they went down and joined him there. 2 And every man in distress, and every man who had a creditor, and every man bitter of soul, assembled themselves to him, and he became captain over them. There were with him about four hundred men.

3 From there David went to Mizpeh of Moab.[b] He said to the king of Moab, "Please let my father and my mother come out and stay with you, until I know what God will do for me." 4 So he left them in the presence of the king of Moab,[c] and they stayed with him all the time that David was in the stronghold. 5 And Gad[d] the prophet spoke to David: "Abide not in the stronghold. Depart from here and enter into the land of Judah." Then David went off and came into the forest of Hereth.

6 Saul learned that David and his men had been located. Saul was
seated in Gibeah beneath the tamarisk tree on the hilltop, spear in
hand, with all his servants standing around him. 7 Saul said to the
servants standing around him, "Listen, you Benjamites! Is the son of
Jesse going to give each of you fields and vineyards? Will he appoint
all of you commanders over thousands and over hundreds, 8 for all
of you have plotted against me! Nobody told me when my son made
a covenant with Jesse's son. None of you cares about me enough to
tell me that my son has stirred up my servant to lie in ambush for
me, as he does now." 9 Then Doeg the Edomite, who was standing
among Saul's servants, spoke up: "I saw Jesse's son come to Nob, to
Ahimelech son of Ahitub. 10 He inquired of Yahweh for him and gave
him provisions and gave him the sword of Goliath the Philistine."
11 Then the king sent to call Ahimelech the priest, son of Ahitub,
and the whole house of his father, the priests that were in Nob; and
they all came to the king. 12 Saul said, "Hear now, son of Ahitub." He
answered, "Here I am, my lord." 13 Saul said to him, "For what reason
have you two plotted against me, you and Jesse's son, in that you gave
him bread and a sword and sought God on his behalf, that he should
rise up against me to lie in ambush, as at this day?" 14 Ahimelech
answered the king and said, "And who among all your servants is
faithful like David, the son-in-law of the king, who has charge of
your guard,[e] and is honored in your house? 15 Was that the first time
I inquired of God for him? Certainly not! The king must not accuse
his servant or anyone in my father's house, because your servant
knew nothing at all about this matter, great or small." 16 The king said,
"You shall surely die, Ahimelech, you and all your father's house."
17 The king commanded the guards[f] standing beside him, "Turn and
put Yahweh's priests to death, because they sided with David. They
knew he was running away, and they did not tell me." But the king's
servants would not stretch out a hand to strike Yahweh's priests. 18
Then the king said to Doeg, "Turn yourself and fall on the priests."
And Doeg the Edomite turned and fell on the priests, and slew on that
day eighty-five persons[g] wearing a linen ephod. 19 He also attacked

Nob, the city of the priests, and put to the sword its men and women, children and infants, oxen, donkeys, and sheep.
20 But one of the sons of Ahimelech son of Ahitub, named Abiathar,[h] escaped and fled after David. 21 Abiathar told David that Saul had killed the priests of Yahweh. 22 David told Abiathar, "I knew that day, with Doeg the Edomite there, that he would surely inform Saul. I myself am to blame for the death[i] of every person in your father's family. 23 Stay with me; do not be afraid. For he who seeks my life seeks your life. With me you will be safe."

Notes

- a (22:1) Adullam was a town in the lowland of Judah, about 16 miles (26 kilometers) southwest of Jerusalem. Its name perhaps means "refuge" (uncertain).
- b (22:3) Mizpeh means "watchtower."
- c (22:4) So the Syriac and the Vulgate (reported). The Hebrew reads "he led them" (vocalized differently); the Septuagint reads "he persuaded the king of Moab" (Brenton, modernized). David's great-grandmother Ruth was from Moab (Ruth 4:17).
- d (22:5) Gad means "good fortune."
- e (22:14) The Hebrew is uncertain, literally "and turns aside to your obedience," often understood as "captain over your bodyguard." The Septuagint reads "executor of all your commands" (Brenton, modernized).
- f (22:17) Hebrew ratsim, the king's guard who ran before his chariot.
- g (22:18) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "three hundred and five men" (Brenton).
- h (22:20) Abiathar means "the father is abundant" or "father of abundance" (uncertain).
- i (22:22) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "I am guilty of the death") and the Vulgate (reported). The Hebrew reads "I have turned against," from a verb of similar form.

Chapter 23

1 Now they told David, "Look, the Philistines are fighting against Keilah[a] and are robbing the threshing floors." 2 So David inquired of Yahweh, "Should I go and attack these Philistines?" Yahweh answered David, "Go, attack the Philistines, and rescue Keilah." 3 But David's men said to him, "Look, we are afraid here in Judah. How much more, then, if we go to Keilah against the ranks of the Philistines!" 4 So David inquired of Yahweh yet again. And Yahweh answered him, "Arise, go down to Keilah, for I am giving the Philistines into your hand."

5 David and his men went to Keilah, fought the Philistines, carried
off their livestock, and inflicted a heavy defeat on them. In this way
David rescued the people of Keilah.
6 When Abiathar son of Ahimelech fled to David at Keilah, he came
down with an ephod in his hand.[b] 7 It was told Saul that David had
come to Keilah. Saul said, "God has handed him over[c] into my hand,
for he is shut in, having entered into a city that has gates and bars." 8
Saul summoned all the people to war, to go down to Keilah to besiege
David and his men. 9 David knew that Saul was devising harm against
him. He said to Abiathar the priest, "Bring the ephod here." 10 Then
David said, "Yahweh, God of Israel, your servant has surely heard
that Saul seeks to come to Keilah to destroy the town on my account.
11 Will the citizens[d] of Keilah hand me over to him? Will Saul come
down as your servant has heard? Yahweh, God of Israel, I ask you to
tell your servant." "He will come down," Yahweh said. 12 Then David
said, "Will the citizens of Keilah surrender me and my men into the
hand of Saul?" Yahweh said, "They will surrender you."
13 Then David and his men, about six hundred, rose up and went out
of Keilah, and wandered wherever they might go. And it was told
Saul that David had slipped away from Keilah, and he ceased from
going out. 14 David dwelt in the wilderness in the strongholds, and he
remained in the hill country in the wilderness of Ziph.[e] Saul sought
him every day, but God did not give him into his hand.
15 David saw[f] that Saul had come out to seek his life. David was in
the wilderness of Ziph at Horesh.[g] 16 Then Jonathan the son of Saul
arose and came to David at Horesh, and he made his hand strong in
God. 17 "Do not be afraid," he told him, "for the hand of my father Saul
will not reach you. You are going to be king over Israel, with me as
your second, and even my father Saul is aware of it." 18 The two of
them made a covenant before Yahweh. David remained at Horesh,
and Jonathan went home.
19 Then the Ziphites came up to Saul at Gibeah, saying, "Does not
David hide himself with us, in the strongholds in Horesh, in the hill
of Hachilah, which lies on the south of Jeshimon?[h] 20 So now, your
majesty, come down whenever you wish, and it will be our duty

to hand him over to the king." 21 Saul said, "May you be blessed by
Yahweh, for you have had compassion on me. 22 Go, I pray you, and
make ready still more. Learn and look at the place where he sets his
foot, and who has seen him there, for it has been told me that he deals
very craftily. 23 Study all the hiding places where he lurks, and return
to me once you are certain.[i] Then I will go with you, and if he is in
the land, I will search him out among all the clans of Judah." 24 So they
arose and went to Ziph before Saul. But David and his men were in
the wilderness of Maon,[j] in the Arabah on the south of Jeshimon. 25
Saul and his men went to seek him. When David was told, he went
down to the rock[k] and stayed in the wilderness of Maon. When Saul
heard that, he pursued after David in the wilderness of Maon. 26 Saul
was going along one side of the mountain, and David and his men
along the other. David was in a hurry to get away from Saul, because
Saul and his men were closing in on David and his men to seize them.
27 Then a messenger came to Saul, saying, "Hurry and come, for the
Philistines have made a raid on the land." 28 So Saul turned back from
pursuing David and went against the Philistines. Therefore that place
was called the Rock of Divisions.[l]
29 David went up from there and lived in the strongholds of En-gedi.[m]

Notes

- a (23:1) Keilah was a town in the lowland of Judah, about 3 miles (5 kilometers) south of Adullam.
- b (23:6) The Septuagint reads "he went down with David to Keilah, having an ephod in his hand" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (23:7) Or "alienated him"; the Hebrew verb usually means "estrange." The Septuagint reads "sold him" (reported).
- d (23:11) Or "lords" (Hebrew baʿale). Likewise in verse 12.
- e (23:14) Ziph was a town in the hill country of Judah, about 4 miles (6 kilometers) southeast of Hebron.
- f (23:15) Or "was afraid." The Hebrew letters can be read either way.
- g (23:15) Or "in the woods." Horesh means "wood" or "thicket."
- h (23:19) Jeshimon means "wasteland," the barren area west of the Dead Sea.
- i (23:23) Or "at a set time." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (23:24) Maon was a town about 8 miles (13 kilometers) south of Hebron.
- k (23:25) Or "to Sela."

- l (23:28) Hebrew Sela-hammahlekoth, perhaps "Rock of Escape" or "Rock of Divisions" (uncertain). The Septuagint reads "The divided Rock" (Brenton).
- m (23:29) En-gedi means "spring of the young goat," an oasis on the west shore of the Dead Sea. In Hebrew this verse is 24:1, and 24:1–22 in English is 24:2–23 in Hebrew.

Chapter 24

1 When Saul returned from pursuing the Philistines, he received
word: "David is in the wilderness of En-gedi."[a] 2 Then Saul took three
thousand chosen men out of all Israel and went to seek David and
his men in front of the Rocks of the Wild Goats.[b] 3 Along the road he
came to some sheep pens, and there was a cave there. Saul went into
it to relieve himself,[c] while David and his men were sitting at the very
back of the cave. 4 David's men said to him, "Here is the day of which
Yahweh said to you, 'Look, I am giving your enemy into your hand,
and you shall do to him as it seems good to you.'" Then David arose
and stealthily cut off the corner of Saul's robe. 5 Afterward David's
heart struck him, because he had cut off the corner of Saul's robe.[d] 6
He said to his men, "Yahweh forbid that I should do this thing to my
lord, Yahweh's anointed, to put out my hand against him, for he is
Yahweh's anointed." 7 So David held back his men with these words
and did not let them rise against Saul. And Saul rose up from the cave
and went on his way.
8 After that David got up, left the cave, and called out to Saul, "My
lord the king!" Saul looked back, and David bowed low with his face
to the ground and did him honor. 9 David said to Saul, "Why do you
listen to the words of men who say, 'Look, David seeks your harm'?
10 This very day you have seen with your own eyes that Yahweh
delivered you into my hand in the cave. Some urged me to kill you,
but I[e] spared you. I said, 'I will not raise a hand against my lord, since
he is Yahweh's anointed.' 11 See, my father, see the corner of your robe
in my hand! I cut off the corner of your robe but did not kill you; so
understand and recognize that there is no wrongdoing or rebellion
in me. I have not sinned against you, yet you are hunting my life
to take it. 12 May Yahweh judge between me and you; may Yahweh
avenge me on you; but my hand shall not be against you. 13 As the

proverb of the ancients says, 'Out of the wicked comes wickedness.' But my hand shall not be against you. 14 After whom has the king of Israel come out? After whom are you chasing? After a dead dog! After a single flea! 15 May Yahweh therefore be judge and decide between me and you, and see and plead my cause, and vindicate me against your hand."[f]

16 And when David had made an end of speaking these words to Saul, Saul said, "Is that your voice, my son David?" And Saul lifted up his voice and wept. 17 He said to David, "You are more righteous than I, for you have repaid me good, while I have repaid you evil. 18 You have declared this day how you have done good to me, for when Yahweh had shut me up into your hand, you did not kill me. 19 For if a man finds his enemy, will he let him go away safely? So may Yahweh reward you with good for what you have done to me this day. 20 Now see, I am sure you will be king, and that the kingdom of Israel will become firm in your hands. 21 Swear to me therefore by Yahweh that you will not cut off my offspring after me, and that you will not destroy my name out of my father's house." 22 David gave Saul his oath. Then Saul went home, and David and his men went up to the stronghold.[g]

Notes

- a (24:1) In Hebrew, 24:1–22 is numbered 24:2–23 (see the note at 23:29).
- b (24:2) Hebrew "the Rocks of the Ibexes" (wild mountain goats). The Septuagint reads "in front of Saddaeem" (Brenton, modernized), taking it as a place name.
- c (24:3) Literally "to cover his feet," a polite expression.
- d (24:5) The Hebrew reads "Saul's corner," that is, the corner of his robe. Cutting the robe's corner may have symbolized taking away his royal authority (compare 15:27–28).
- e (24:10) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "I would not slay you, but spared you") and other ancient witnesses. The Hebrew reads "but it spared you," perhaps meaning "my eye spared you."
- f (24:15) Or "deliver me from your hand."
- g (24:22) The Septuagint reads "the stronghold of Messera" (Brenton), taking the Hebrew word for "stronghold" as a place name.

Chapter 25

1 Then Samuel died. All Israel assembled and lamented him, and they
laid him in the grave at his house in Ramah. And David rose and went
down into the wilderness of Paran.[a]
2 Now a man in Maon had his property in Carmel.[b] He was a very rich
man, owning three thousand sheep and a thousand goats, and he was
at Carmel for the shearing of his sheep. 3 The man's name was Nabal,[c]
and his wife's name was Abigail.[d] She was intelligent and beautiful,
but he was harsh and mean in his dealings. He was a Calebite.[e] 4
David heard in the wilderness that Nabal was shearing his sheep. 5 So
David sent ten young men, and David said to the young men, "Go up
to Carmel, and go to Nabal, and greet him in my name. 6 Thus you
shall say: 'Long life to you![f] Peace be to you, and peace be to your
house, and peace be to all that you have. 7 Now I have heard that you
have shearers. Your shepherds have been with us, and we did them
no harm, and nothing of theirs went missing all the days they were
in Carmel. 8 Ask your young men, and they will tell you. Therefore let
my young men find favor in your eyes, for we have come on a good
day.[g] Please give whatever your hand finds to your servants and to
your son David.'"
9 When David's young men came, they spoke to Nabal all these words
in the name of David, and then they waited. 10 Nabal answered David's
servants, "Who is David? Who is the son of Jesse? Many are the
servants these days who are breaking away, each from his master.
11 Should I take my bread and my water, and the meat I butchered
for my shearers, and give them to men who come from I do not
know where?" 12 David's young men turned around, went back, and
reported all this to him. 13 David told his men, "Each of you put on his
sword!" Each put on his sword, and David put on his as well. About
four hundred men went up with David, and two hundred stayed with
the supplies.
14 But one of the young men told Abigail, Nabal's wife, "Look, David
sent messengers out of the wilderness to greet our master, and he
railed at them. 15 Yet the men were very good to us, and we were not
harmed, and we did not miss anything all the time we went about

with them, when we were in the fields. 16 They were a wall to us both
by night and by day, all the while we were with them keeping the
sheep. 17 Now therefore take thought and see what you will do, for
evil is resolved against our master and against his whole household.
He is so base a fellow[h] that no one can say a word to him."
18 Abigail hurried to gather two hundred loaves, two skins of wine,
five sheep ready for cooking, about a bushel of roasted grain,[i] a
hundred raisin clusters, and two hundred fig cakes, and she loaded
these on donkeys. 19 She said to her young men, "Go on before me;
look, I am coming after you." But she did not tell her husband Nabal.
20 And as she was riding on the donkey, going down in the shelter of
the hill, there came David and his men descending to meet her, and
she encountered them. 21 Now David had said, "It was all for nothing
that I kept watch over everything this man owns in the wilderness, so
that not a thing of his was lost; and he has paid me back evil for good.
22 God do so to David,[j] and more also, if I let remain until daybreak a
single male[k] out of all that are his."
23 When Abigail saw David, she got down quickly from her donkey,
threw herself face down before David, and bowed to the ground. 24
Falling at his feet, she said, "Upon me, my lord, upon me let the
iniquity rest. Let your handmaid, I pray, speak in your hearing, and
listen to the words of your handmaid. 25 Please, my lord, pay no
attention to this worthless man Nabal, for he is just what his name
says. Nabal is his name, and folly goes with him. But I, your servant,
did not see the young men my lord sent. 26 Now, my lord, as Yahweh
lives and as you yourself live, since Yahweh has held you back from
bloodguilt and from winning the victory by your own hand, may your
enemies and all who seek to harm my lord be like Nabal. 27 And now
this gift[l] which your servant has brought to my lord, let it be given to
the young men who follow my lord. 28 Please forgive the trespass of
your handmaid. For Yahweh will certainly make my lord a sure house,
because my lord is fighting the battles of Yahweh, and evil shall not
be found in you all your days. 29 Should a man rise up to chase you
and to seek your soul, yet the soul of my lord shall be bound up in the
bundle of life[m] with Yahweh your God; but the souls of your enemies,

them he will hurl away as out of the pocket of a sling. 30 And when
Yahweh has done to my lord according to all the good that he has
spoken concerning you, and has appointed you prince over Israel, 31
my lord shall have no cause of grief or stumbling of heart, either for
having shed blood without cause or for my lord having saved himself.
And when Yahweh has dealt well with my lord, then remember your
handmaid."
32 David said to Abigail, "Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Israel, who
sent you this day to meet me! 33 May you be blessed for your good
judgment, and may you be blessed, because you have kept me today
from bloodguilt and from avenging myself with my own hand. 34 As
surely as Yahweh, the God of Israel, lives, who has kept me from
harming you, if you had not come quickly to meet me, not one male
would have been left to Nabal by morning." 35 Then David received
from her hand what she had brought him, and he said to her, "Go up
in peace to your house. See, I have listened to your voice and have
lifted up your face."[n]
36 Abigail went back to Nabal, who was holding a feast in his house, a
feast fit for a king. Nabal was in good spirits and very drunk, so she
told him nothing at all until dawn. 37 In the morning, when the wine
had gone out of Nabal, his wife told him these things, and his heart
died within him, and he became as a stone. 38 About ten days later
Yahweh struck Nabal, and he died.
39 When David heard that Nabal was dead, he said, "Blessed be Yah-
weh, who has defended me against the insult from Nabal and kept his
servant from doing wrong. Yahweh has returned Nabal's wickedness
on his own head." Then David sent a message to Abigail asking her to
be his wife. 40 When David's servants came to Abigail at Carmel, they
spoke to her, saying, "David has sent us to you to take you to him as
his wife." 41 She arose and bowed with her face to the earth and said,
"Look, your handmaid is a servant to wash the feet of the servants of
my lord." 42 Abigail got up quickly and rode off on a donkey, with five
of her maids going with her. She followed David's messengers and
became his wife.

43 David had also taken Ahinoam from Jezreel,[o] and the two of them
were wives to him. 44 Saul had given Michal his daughter, David's wife,
to Palti[p] son of Laish, who was of Gallim.

Notes

- a (25:1) So the traditional Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "Maon" (Brenton), as in verse 2.
- b (25:2) This Carmel (meaning "garden land" or "orchard") was a town in Judah near Maon, about 7 miles (11 kilometers) south of Hebron, not Mount Carmel in the north.
- c (25:3) Nabal means "fool" (see verse 25). The word suggests a person who is morally senseless.
- d (25:3) Abigail means "my father is joy" (uncertain).
- e (25:3) Or "according to his heart"; the Hebrew letters can be read either way. Calebites were descendants of Caleb, who had received the region of Hebron (Joshua 14:13–14). The Septuagint reads "a man of a dog-like nature" (reported), playing on the name Caleb, which is similar to the word for "dog."
- f (25:6) The Hebrew is uncertain, literally "to the living one."
- g (25:8) A feast day, the time of sheep-shearing.
- h (25:17) Hebrew "a son of Belial." Likewise in verse 25.
- i (25:18) Hebrew "five seahs," about 33 quarts (37 liters); a seah was about a third of an ephah. The Septuagint reads "five ephahs of fine flour" and "one homer of dried grapes" (Brenton, modernized) instead of the hundred clusters.
- j (25:22) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "So God do to David"). The Hebrew reads "to the enemies of David," apparently a scribal change to avoid a curse falling on David himself.
- k (25:22) Hebrew "one who urinates against a wall," a coarse expression for a male. Likewise in verse 34.
- l (25:27) Hebrew "blessing."
- m (25:29) An image of a person's life kept safe like a precious thing tied in a bundle.
- n (25:35) That is, "granted your request."
- o (25:43) Ahinoam means "my brother is pleasantness." This Jezreel was a town in Judah (Joshua 15:56), not the northern city.
- p (25:44) Called Paltiel in 2 Samuel 3:15. Palti means "my deliverance"; Paltiel means "God is my deliverance." Gallim was a town near Gibeah (Isaiah 10:30).

Chapter 26

1 Then the Ziphites came to Saul at Gibeah, saying, "Is David not
concealing himself on the hill of Hachilah, which faces Jeshimon?" 2
So Saul rose and went down into the wilderness of Ziph, having with
him three thousand picked men of Israel, to search for David in the

wilderness of Ziph. 3 Saul pitched his camp beside the road on the hill
of Hachilah, opposite Jeshimon. David was staying in the wilderness,
and he saw that Saul had followed him into it. 4 David therefore sent
out spies and learned for certain that Saul had come.[a]
5 Then David rose and came to the place where Saul had camped.
David saw where Saul was lying, and Abner son of Ner,[b] the captain of
his host; Saul lay inside the camp ring,[c] and the troops were camped
round about him. 6 David asked Ahimelech the Hittite and Abishai[d]
son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother, "Who will go down into the camp with
me to Saul?" "I will go with you," said Abishai. 7 So David and Abishai
came to the people by night, and there Saul lay sleeping inside the
camp ring, his spear stuck in the earth at his head, and Abner and the
people lying around him. 8 Then Abishai said to David, "God has shut
up your enemy into your hand this day. Now let me pin him to the
earth with the spear in one stroke. I will not need to strike him twice."
9 But David said to Abishai, "Do not destroy him. For who can put
forth his hand against Yahweh's anointed and be guiltless?" 10 David
said further, "As Yahweh lives, Yahweh himself shall strike him: or
his day shall come to die, or he shall descend into battle and perish.
11 Yahweh forbid that I should put forth my hand against Yahweh's
anointed. But now take, I pray, the spear that is at his head and the
jug of water, and let us go." 12 David took the spear and water jug from
beside Saul's head, and they left. No one saw it or knew about it, and
no one woke up; they were all asleep, because Yahweh had put them
into a deep sleep.
13 Then David crossed over to the far side and stood on the top of the
hill at a distance, with a wide space between them. 14 And David called
out to the people and to Abner son of Ner, "Will you not answer,
Abner?" Abner answered, "Who are you that call to the king?" 15 Then
David said to Abner, "Are you not a valiant man? And who in Israel
is your equal? Why then have you not kept watch over your lord
the king? For one of the people came in to destroy the king your
lord. 16 This thing that you have done is not good. As Yahweh lives,
you deserve to die,[e] because you have not watched over your master,

Yahweh's anointed. And now look about: where is the king's spear, and the jug of water that was at his head?"
17 Saul recognized David's voice and said, "Is this your voice, my son David?" David said, "It is my voice, my lord the king." 18 He went on, "Why does my lord pursue his servant? What did I do? What is the wrong on my hands? 19 Now therefore, I pray, let my lord the king hear the words of his servant. If it is Yahweh who has stirred you up against me, let him accept an offering;[f] but if it is the sons of men, cursed be they before Yahweh, for they have driven me out this day so that I have no share in the inheritance of Yahweh, saying, 'Go, serve other gods.' 20 Now therefore, let not my blood fall to the earth away from the presence of Yahweh. For the king of Israel has come out to seek a single flea,[g] as one hunts a partridge in the mountains."
21 Then Saul said, "I have sinned. Come back, my son David, for I will no longer do you harm, because my life was precious in your eyes this day. Look, I have acted the fool and have erred very greatly." 22 "Here is the king's spear," David answered.[h] "Let one of the young men cross over and take it. 23 Yahweh rewards each man for his righteousness and faithfulness. Yahweh delivered you into my hands today, but I refused to raise my hand against Yahweh's anointed. 24 And see, just as your life was valued highly this day in my eyes, so may my life be valued highly in the eyes of Yahweh, and may he deliver me out of every distress." 25 Then Saul said to David, "Blessed are you, my son David! You will both do great things and surely prevail." So David went his way, and Saul returned to his place.

Notes

- a (26:4) Or "had come to Nacon" (uncertain); the Hebrew word can be read as a place name.
- b (26:5) Abner means "my father is a lamp" (uncertain). Ner means "lamp."
- c (26:5) Or "within the circle of wagons." Likewise in verse 7.
- d (26:6) Ahimelech means "my brother is king." Abishai means "my father is a gift" (uncertain). Zeruiah, David's sister (1 Chronicles 2:16), was mother of Abishai, Joab, and Asahel.
- e (26:16) Hebrew "you are sons of death."
- f (26:19) Literally "let him smell an offering," that is, let him be appeased by a sacrifice.

- g (26:20) The Septuagint reads “to seek your life” (reported) instead of “a single flea” (compare 24:14).
- h (26:22) So the traditional Hebrew reading (qere). The written text (ketiv) reads “Here is the king’s spear.”

Chapter 27

1 David said to himself, “One day Saul will surely kill me. The best
thing for me is to flee quickly to Philistine territory. Then Saul will
stop looking for me within the borders of Israel, and I will be out of his
reach.” 2 So David set out with his six hundred men and crossed over
to Achish son of Maoch, king of Gath. 3 And David lived with Achish
at Gath, he and his men, every man with his household, David with
his two wives, Ahinoam the Jezreelitess and Abigail the Carmelitess,
Nabal’s widow. 4 When it was told Saul that David had fled to Gath,
he sought him no more.
5 Then David said to Achish, “If now I have found favor in your eyes,
let them give me a place in one of the country towns, that I may live
there. For why should your servant live in the royal city with you?” 6
That day Achish gave him Ziklag.[a] That is why Ziklag belongs to the
kings of Judah to this day. 7 The number of the days that David lived
in the country of the Philistines was a year and four months.[b]
8 David and his men went up and raided the Geshurites, the Girzites,[c]
and the Amalekites, who had lived in the land since ancient times,
in the region stretching toward Shur and as far as Egypt. 9 Whenever
David attacked a district, he left no man or woman alive; he took
the sheep, cattle, donkeys, camels, and clothing, and then returned to
Achish. 10 When Achish asked, “Where have you raided today?” David
would say, “Upon the south of Judah,” or “Upon the south country
of the Jerahmeelites,” or “Upon the south country of the Kenites.”[d] 11
David left no man or woman alive to bring word to Gath, thinking,
“They might tell on us and say, ‘This is what David did.’” This was
his practice all the time he lived in Philistine territory. 12 And Achish
trusted David, thinking, “He has made himself utterly odious to his
people Israel; therefore he shall be my servant forever.”

Notes

- a (27:6) Ziklag was a town in the Negeb, in the south of Judah; its exact location is uncertain.
- b (27:7) Hebrew "days and four months"; "days" here means a year. The Septuagint reads "four months" (reported).
- c (27:8) So the traditional written text (ketiv); the margin reads "Gezrites." Some Septuagint manuscripts lack this name (reported).
- d (27:10) Hebrew "the Negeb," meaning "dry land," the southern region of Judah.

Chapter 28

1 About that time the Philistines mustered their armies to make war
on Israel. Achish told David, "You must understand that you and your
men will march out with me in the army." 2 David answered Achish,
"So be it; you shall learn what your servant will do." And Achish
replied to David, "So be it; I will make you keeper of my head[a] for
all time."
3 Now Samuel had died, and all Israel had lamented him and buried
him in Ramah, his own city. And Saul had driven out of the land
those who called up the dead and those who consulted spirits.[b] 4 So
the Philistines were gathered together, and they came and pitched at
Shunem;[c] and Saul assembled all Israel, and they pitched at Gilboa.[d]
5 When Saul saw the army of the Philistines, he was afraid, and his
heart trembled greatly. 6 When Saul inquired of Yahweh, Yahweh did
not answer him, neither by dreams, nor by Urim, nor by prophets.
7 Saul said to his servants, "Find me a woman who is a medium,[e] so
that I can go and consult her." "There is a medium at En-dor,"[f] they
told him.
8 Saul put on other clothes to disguise himself and went with two
men. They came to the woman by night, and he said, "Please practice
divination for me by a spirit, and call up the person I name to you."
9 The woman answered him, "You surely know what Saul has done:
he has removed the mediums and spiritists from the land. Why are
you laying a trap for me, to get me killed?" 10 But Saul swore to her
by Yahweh, "As Yahweh lives, no punishment shall come upon you
for this thing." 11 Then the woman asked, "Whom am I to bring up
to you?" He answered, "Samuel; bring him up to me." 12 When the
woman saw Samuel, she cried out with a loud voice. And the woman

spoke to Saul, saying, “Why have you deceived me? You are Saul!”
13 The king told her, “Have no fear. What do you see?” The woman
answered Saul, “I see a divine being[g] rising out of the earth.” 14 He said
to her, “What form has he?” She said, “An aged man is coming up,
covered with a mantle.” Then Saul perceived that it was Samuel, and
he bowed with his face to the ground and did homage.
15 Samuel said to Saul, “Why have you disturbed me by calling me up?”
Saul answered, “I am in deep distress. The Philistines are fighting
against me, and God has turned away from me. He no longer answers
me, either through prophets or through dreams, so I have called on
you to let me know what I should do.” 16 Samuel said, “Why ask
me, now that Yahweh has turned away from you and become your
enemy?[h] 17 Yahweh has done to you[i] just as he spoke by me. Yahweh
has torn the kingdom out of your hand and given it to your neighbor,
to David. 18 Because you did not listen to the voice of Yahweh, nor
execute the heat of his anger upon Amalek, for that reason Yahweh
has done this thing to you this day. 19 Moreover, Yahweh will also give
Israel along with you into the hand of the Philistines, and tomorrow
you and your sons shall be with me. Yahweh will give the army of
Israel also into the hand of the Philistines.”
20 Then Saul fell at once full length on the ground and was greatly
afraid because of the words of Samuel. And there was no strength in
him, for he had eaten no bread all day and all night. 21 The woman
approached Saul and saw how terrified he was. She said, “Your
servant has obeyed you; I took my life in my hands and did what
you told me. 22 Now please listen to your servant. Let me put a bit of
food in front of you so that you can eat and regain your strength for
the journey.” 23 He refused and said, “I will not eat.” But his servants,
together with the woman, pressed him, and he listened to their voice.
So he rose from the ground and sat on the bed. 24 Now the woman had
a fattened calf in the house, and she hurried and slaughtered it, and
she took flour and kneaded it and baked unleavened bread from it. 25
She served it to Saul and his servants, and they ate. Then they got up
and left that same night.

Notes

- a (28:2) That is, “my bodyguard.”
- b (28:3) Hebrew ʾovot and yiddeʿonim, those who claimed to consult the spirits of the dead. Likewise in verse 9.
- c (28:4) Shunem was a town in the territory of Issachar, on the slope of the hill of Moreh.
- d (28:4) Gilboa was a mountain ridge south of the Jezreel Valley.
- e (28:7) Hebrew “a woman who is mistress of a spirit” (baʿalat ʾov).
- f (28:7) En-dor means “spring of the dwelling” (uncertain), a town north of the hill of Moreh.
- g (28:13) Or “a godlike being” or “divine beings” (Hebrew ʾelohim, with a plural verb). The Septuagint reads “gods ascending out of the earth” (Brenton).
- h (28:16) The Hebrew word ʿar is uncertain; perhaps “adversary” (an Aramaic sense). The Septuagint reads “is with your neighbor” (reported).
- i (28:17) So many Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint (reported); the traditional text reads “to him,” that is, to David.

Chapter 29

1 Now the Philistines gathered all their forces to Aphek,[a] while Israel
was camped by the spring that is in Jezreel. 2 Now the lords of the
Philistines were marching past by hundreds and by thousands, and
David and his men were marching past at the rear with Achish. 3
Then the princes of the Philistines said, “What are these Hebrews
here for?” And Achish answered the princes of the Philistines, “Is not
this David, servant of Saul the king of Israel, who has been with me
these days, or these years? I have found no fault in him from the day
he went over to me until this day.” 4 But the princes of the Philistines
were angry with him and said to him, “Make the man go back, so that
he returns to his place that you appointed him. He shall not go down
with us to the battle, lest in the battle he become an adversary[b] to
us. For with what could this man win back the goodwill of his lord?
Would it not be with the heads of these men here? 5 Is not this the
David of whom they answered one another in the dances, saying,
‘Saul has slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands’?”
6 So Achish called David and told him, “As Yahweh lives,[c] you have
been honest, and I would be pleased to have you serve alongside me
in the army, since I have found no fault in you from the day you
came to me until now. Even so, the other rulers do not approve of
you. 7 So turn around now and go back in peace, so that you will not

offend the Philistine rulers." [8] David said to Achish, "But what have I done? And what have you found in your servant from the day that I came before you until this day, that I may not go and fight against the enemies of my lord the king?" [9] Achish answered David, "I know that you are as good in my eyes as a messenger[d] of God. Nevertheless, the commanders of the Philistines have said, 'He shall not go up with us to the battle.' [10] So get up early in the morning, together with your lord's servants who came with you,[e] and leave as soon as it is light." [11] So David set out early, he and his men, to leave in the morning and return to the land of the Philistines. But the Philistines went up to Jezreel.

Notes

- a (29:1) Aphek was a town in the Sharon plain, the gathering place before the battle of 4:1.
- b (29:4) Hebrew satan, "adversary."
- c (29:6) A Philistine king swearing by Yahweh may reflect courtesy toward David.
- d (29:9) Or "angel."
- e (29:10) The Septuagint adds "and go to the place where I appointed you, and entertain no evil thought in your heart, for you are good in my sight" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 30

[1] On the third day David and his men arrived at Ziklag. The Amalekites had raided the Negeb and Ziklag; they had struck Ziklag and burned it down, [2] and had taken captive the women and everyone else in it, young and old. They had killed no one, but had carried them away as they went on their way. [3] When David and his men came to the town, there it was, burned with fire, and their wives and their sons and their daughters taken captive. [4] Then David and the people who were with him lifted up their voices and wept until they had no more strength to weep. [5] David's two wives also had been taken captive, Ahinoam the Jezreelitess and Abigail the widow of Nabal the Carmelite. [6] And David was in great straits, for the people spoke of stoning him, because the soul of all the people was bitter, each man for his sons and for his daughters. But David strengthened himself in Yahweh his God.

7 David said to Abiathar the priest, son of Ahimelech, “Bring the
ephod here to me, I pray.” So Abiathar brought the ephod to David. 8
David asked Yahweh, “Should I chase this raiding party? Will I catch
them?” “Chase them,” he answered, “for you will certainly catch them
and rescue the captives.” 9 So David went, he and the six hundred
men who were with him, and they came to the brook Besor,[a] where
those who were left behind stayed. 10 But David pursued, he and four
hundred men, while two hundred stayed behind who were too faint
to cross the brook Besor.
11 They found an Egyptian in the field and brought him to David. They
gave him bread, and he ate, and they gave him water to drink. 12 They
also gave him a slice of fig cake and two raisin cakes. After he ate,
his strength returned, for he had eaten no food and drunk no water
for three days and three nights. 13 David said to him, “Whose are you?
And from where do you come?” He said, “I am an Egyptian lad, a
slave of an Amalekite man. My master abandoned me three days ago,
because I fell ill. 14 We made a raid on the Negeb of the Cherethites,[b]
on the territory of Judah, and on the Negeb of Caleb, and we burned
Ziklag.” 15 David said to him, “Will you bring me down to this band?”
He said, “Swear to me by God that you will not kill me or deliver me
into the hands of my master, and I will bring you down to this band.”
16 When he had brought him down, look, they were scattered over the
face of all the land, eating and drinking and feasting, on account of
the vast plunder they had seized out of the Philistines’ land and out of
Judah’s land. 17 And David smote them from the dusk until the evening
of the following day,[c] and not one man of them escaped except four
hundred young men who mounted camels and fled. 18 David recovered
all that the Amalekites had taken, and David rescued his two wives.
19 There was nothing lacking to them, neither small nor great, neither
sons nor daughters, neither plunder nor anything they had seized.
All of it David brought back. 20 David also took all the flocks and the
herds, which they drove before those other livestock, and they said,
“This is David’s spoil.”[d]
21 Then David came to the two hundred men who had been too faint to
follow David, whom they had left at the brook Besor. They went out

to meet David and the people who were with him. When David came near to the people, he greeted them. 22 Then answered all the evil men and the base fellows[e] among the men who had gone with David, and said, "Since they went not with us, we will give them nothing of the plunder that we have rescued, but only to every man his wife and his children, that they may lead them away and go." 23 But David said, "You shall not do so, my brothers, with that which Yahweh has given to us, who has kept us safe and has delivered the raiding band that came upon us into our hand. 24 And who will hearken to you in this matter? For as his portion is that goes down to the battle, so shall his portion be that remains with the baggage. They shall share alike." 25 And from that day forward he made it a statute and an ordinance for Israel, to this day.

26 When David reached Ziklag, he sent part of the plunder to his friends, the elders of Judah, with this message: "Here is a gift[f] for you from the plunder taken from Yahweh's enemies." 27 He sent to them in Bethel, and to them in Ramoth of the south, and to them in Jattir, 28 and to them in Aroer, and to them in Siphmoth, and to them in Eshtemoa, 29 and to them in Racal, and to them in the cities of the Jerahmeelites, and to them in the cities of the Kenites, 30 and to them in Hormah, and to them in Bor-ashan,[g] and to them in Athach, 31 and to them in Hebron, and to every place where David himself and his men had been accustomed to go.

Notes

- a (30:9) Besor was a stream (a wadi) south of Ziklag, flowing west to the Mediterranean.
- b (30:14) The Cherethites were a people related to the Philistines, perhaps from Crete. Some of them later served in David's bodyguard (2 Samuel 8:18).
- c (30:17) The Hebrew is uncertain, literally "from the twilight until the evening of their morrow."
- d (30:20) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- e (30:22) Hebrew "men of Belial."
- f (30:26) Hebrew "blessing."
- g (30:30) So many Hebrew manuscripts (reported); others read "Cor-ashan." Bor-ashan means "smoking pit."

Chapter 31

1 Now the Philistines were fighting against Israel, and the men of
Israel fled before the Philistines and fell slain on Mount Gilboa.
2 The Philistines closed in on Saul and his sons and killed Saul's
sons Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malchi-shua.[a] 3 The battle pressed hard
against Saul, and the archers, the men with bows, found him, and he
was badly wounded by the archers.[b] 4 Then Saul said to his armor-
bearer, "Draw your sword and run me through with it, lest these
uncircumcised come and run me through and make sport of me." But
his armor-bearer would not, for he was greatly afraid. So Saul took
the sword and fell upon it. 5 When his armor-bearer saw that Saul
was dead, he also fell upon his own sword and died with him. 6 So
Saul died, and his three sons, and his armor-bearer, and all his men,
on that same day together.
7 When the Israelites on the other side of the valley and across the
Jordan saw that Israel's army had fled and that Saul and his sons were
dead, they abandoned their towns and ran away, and the Philistines
moved in and settled there. 8 The next day, when the Philistines came
to strip the slain, they found Saul and his three sons fallen on Mount
Gilboa. 9 They cut off his head and stripped off his armor and sent
them round about the land of the Philistines, to proclaim the tidings
in the temples of their idols and among the people. 10 They put his
armor in the house of the Ashtaroth,[c] and they fastened his body to
the wall of Beth-shan.[d]
11 But when the inhabitants of Jabesh-gilead heard what the
Philistines had done to Saul, 12 all their brave men set out and traveled
all night. They took Saul's body and his sons' bodies down from the
wall of Beth-shan, brought them to Jabesh, and burned them there.[e]
13 And they took their bones and buried them under the tamarisk tree
in Jabesh, and they fasted seven days.

Notes

- a (31:2) Abinadab means "my father is generous." Malchi-shua means "my king is salvation" (uncertain).
- b (31:3) Or "he was greatly afraid of the archers." The Septuagint reads "he was wounded under the ribs" (Brenton, modernized).

- c (31:10) The plural of Ashtoreth (Astarte), a Canaanite goddess. The Septuagint reads “the temple of Astarte” (Brenton). First Chronicles 10:10 adds that they fastened his head in the temple of Dagon.
- d (31:10) Beth-shan means “house of quiet” (uncertain), a city at the junction of the Jezreel and Jordan valleys.
- e (31:12) Burning the bodies was not the usual Israelite practice. Some have reported that the verb here may mean “anointed with spices” (scholarly review). First Chronicles 10:12 does not mention the burning.

2 Samuel

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Now it came about after the death of Saul, when David had returned
from striking down the Amalekites, that David remained two days
in Ziklag. 2 On the third day, look, a man came out of the camp from
Saul, with his garments torn and earth upon his head. And as he came
to David, he fell to the ground and did obeisance. 3 David said to him,
"From where do you come?" He said to him, "Out of the camp of Israel
I have escaped." 4 David said to him, "How did the matter go? Tell me,
I pray." He answered, "The people fled from the battle, and many of
the people also have fallen and are dead; and Saul and Jonathan his
son are dead too." 5 Then David said to the young man who was telling
him, "How do you know that Saul and Jonathan his son are dead?" 6
The young man who brought him the report said, "I chanced to come
upon Mount Gilboa, and look, Saul was propped upon his spear, and
look, the chariots and the masters of horse were following hard upon
him. 7 When he looked behind him, he saw me and called to me. And
I answered, 'Here am I.' 8 He said to me, 'Who are you?' I answered
him, 'I am an Amalekite.' 9 He said to me, 'Stand over me, I pray, and
kill me, for dizziness[a] has seized me, though my life is still whole in
me.' 10 So I stood over him and killed him, because I was sure that he
could not live after he had fallen. And I took the crown that was on
his head and the band that was on his arm, and I have brought them
here to my lord."
11 Then David seized his clothes and rent them; likewise every man
that was with him. 12 They mourned and wept and fasted until evening
for Saul and for Jonathan his son and for the people of Yahweh[b] and
for the house of Israel, because they had fallen by the sword.
13 David said to the young man who told him, "Where are you from?"
He answered, "I am the son of a sojourner, an Amalekite." 14 David

said to him, “How were you not afraid to put forth your hand to destroy Yahweh’s anointed?” 15 Then David called one of the young men and said, “Go near and fall upon him.” And he struck him so that he died. 16 David said to him, “Your blood be upon your own head, for your own mouth has testified against you, saying, ‘I have killed Yahweh’s anointed.’”
17 Then David lamented with this lament over Saul and over Jonathan his son, 18 and he said it should be taught to the sons of Judah: the Bow.[c] Look, it is written in the Book of Jashar.[d] 19 “Your glory,[e] O Israel, is slain upon your high places! How are the mighty fallen! 20 Tell it not in Gath, and do not proclaim it in Ashkelon’s streets, or the daughters of the Philistines will celebrate, and the daughters of the uncircumcised will gloat. 21 You mountains of Gilboa, let there be no dew nor rain upon you, nor fields of offerings![f] For there the shield of the mighty was defiled, the shield of Saul, not anointed with oil.[g] 22 From the blood of the slain, from the fat of the mighty, the bow of Jonathan turned not back, and the sword of Saul returned not empty. 23 Saul and Jonathan, beloved and lovely! In their lives and in their death they were not divided. They were swifter than eagles; they were stronger than lions. 24 You daughters of Israel, weep over Saul, who clothed you in scarlet with delights, who put ornaments of gold upon your apparel. 25 How the mighty have fallen in the thick of battle! Jonathan lies dead on your heights. 26 I grieve for you, my brother Jonathan; you were dear to me. Your love for me was more wonderful than the love of women. 27 How are the mighty fallen, and the weapons of war perished!”

Notes

- a (1:9) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; perhaps “cramp” or “agony.” The Septuagint reads “a dreadful darkness” (Brenton).
- b (1:12) The Septuagint reads “for the people of Judah” (reported).
- c (1:18) The Hebrew is uncertain. “The Bow” may be the title of the lament (see verse 22). The Septuagint lacks the word (Brenton, “he gave orders to teach it the sons of Judah”).
- d (1:18) Jashar means “upright.” The Book of Jashar was an ancient collection of poems, now lost (see also Joshua 10:13). The Septuagint reads “the book of Right” (Brenton).

- e (1:19) Or "The gazelle." The Hebrew word tsevi can mean either "beauty" or "gazelle."
- f (1:21) The Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "nor fields of first-fruits" (Brenton).
- g (1:21) Leather shields were rubbed with oil before battle. The Septuagint likewise reads "the shield of Saul was not anointed with oil" (Brenton). Some read the phrase as referring to Saul himself, "no longer anointed" (scholarly review).

Chapter 2

1 After this David inquired of Yahweh, saying, "Shall I go up into any
of the towns of Judah?" Yahweh said to him, "Go up." David said, "To
where shall I go up?" And he said, "To Hebron."[a] 2 David went up
there with his two wives, Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail, the widow
of Nabal of Carmel. 3 And David brought up his men who were with
him, every man with his household, and they settled in the towns
of Hebron. 4 Then the men of Judah came, and there they anointed
David king over the house of Judah. They told David, "It was the men
of Jabesh-gilead who buried Saul." 5 So David sent messengers to the
men of Jabesh-gilead and said to them, "Blessed be you of Yahweh,
because you have shown this kindness to your lord, to Saul, and have
buried him. 6 Now may Yahweh show steadfast love and faithfulness
to you. And I also will do you good, because you have done this thing.
7 So now strengthen your hands and be sons of valor; for Saul your
master is dead, and me the house of Judah has anointed as king over
them."
8 Meanwhile Abner son of Ner, the commander of Saul's army, had
taken Saul's son Ish-bosheth[b] and moved him across to Mahanaim,[c] 9
and he made him king over Gilead and over the Ashurites[d] and over
Jezreel and over Ephraim and over Benjamin and over all Israel. 10 Ish-
bosheth, Saul's son, was forty years old when he began to reign over
Israel, and he reigned two years. But the house of Judah followed
David. 11 The number of the days that David was king in Hebron over
the house of Judah was seven years and six months.
12 Abner son of Ner and the servants of Ish-bosheth son of Saul went
out from Mahanaim to Gibeon. 13 And Joab[e] son of Zeruiah and the
servants of David went out and met them by the pool of Gibeon. They

sat down, the one band on the one side of the pool and the other on the other side of the pool. 14 Abner said to Joab, "Let the young men arise now and contend before us." Joab said, "Let them arise." 15 Then they arose and went over by number, twelve for Benjamin and for Ish-bosheth son of Saul, and twelve of the servants of David. 16 Each man caught his fellow by the head and thrust his sword into his fellow's side, and they fell down together. Therefore that place was called Helkath-hazzurim,[f] which is in Gibeon. 17 And the fighting grew exceedingly hard that day, and Abner was beaten, and the men of Israel with him, before David's servants.

18 The three sons of Zeruiah were there, Joab and Abishai and Asahel.[g] Asahel was as light of foot as one of the gazelles in the field. 19 Asahel pursued after Abner, and in going he turned neither to the right hand nor to the left from following Abner. 20 Then Abner looked behind him and said, "Is that you, Asahel?" He answered, "It is I." 21 Abner said to him, "Turn aside to your right hand or to your left, and lay hold of one of the young men and take his gear for yourself." But Asahel would not turn aside from following him. 22 Abner told Asahel again, "Turn aside from following me! Why should I strike you to the ground? How could I hold up my head before your brother Joab?" 23 Yet he refused to turn aside. So Abner smote him in the belly with the hinder end of the spear, and the spear went out behind him; and he fell there and died in his place. And every one who came to the spot where Asahel fell and died halted.

24 But Joab and Abishai chased after Abner. And the sun went down as they reached the hill of Ammah, that lies before Giah by the road to the wilderness of Gibeon. 25 The Benjamites rallied behind Abner and formed a single group, taking their stand on the top of a hill. 26 Abner called out to Joab, "Must the sword go on devouring forever? Surely you realize this will end in bitterness. How long before you tell your men to stop pursuing their brothers?" 27 "As God lives," Joab answered, "if you had not spoken up, the men would not have given up pursuing their brothers until morning."[h] 28 So Joab blew the trumpet, and all the people stood still and pursued Israel no more, nor did they fight any more. 29 All that night Abner and his men traveled

through the Arabah. They crossed over the Jordan, passed through the whole Bithron,[i] and came to Mahanaim.

30 Joab gave up the chase after Abner and assembled all his troops. Nineteen of David's men were missing, besides Asahel. 31 But the servants of David had struck of Benjamin and of Abner's men three hundred and sixty men, and they died. 32 They took up Asahel and buried him in the tomb of his father, which was in Bethlehem. And Joab and his men went all night, and the day broke upon them at Hebron.

Notes

- a (2:1) Hebron was the chief city of Judah, about 19 miles (31 kilometers) south of Jerusalem. Its name perhaps means "association" or "alliance."
- b (2:8) Ish-bosheth means "man of shame." His original name was Ishbaal or Eshbaal, "man of the lord" (1 Chronicles 8:33); scribes replaced "baal" with "bosheth" ("shame") to avoid the name of the god Baal. The Septuagint reads "Jebosthe" (Brenton). Likewise throughout.
- c (2:8) Mahanaim means "two camps" (Genesis 32:2), a town east of the Jordan.
- d (2:9) So the Hebrew. Some ancient versions read "Geshurites" (reported); others suggest "Asherites."
- e (2:13) Joab means "Yahweh is father."
- f (2:16) Helkath-hazzurim means "field of flints" or "field of blades" (uncertain). The Septuagint reads "Portion of the Treacherous ones" (reported).
- g (2:18) Asahel means "God has made."
- h (2:27) Or "If you had not spoken, the people would have given up the pursuit of their brothers only in the morning." The Hebrew can be read either way.
- i (2:29) Or "the whole morning"; the Hebrew word bitron may be a place name or mean "ravine."

Chapter 3

1 Now the war between Saul's house and David's house was long. And David went on growing ever stronger, but the house of Saul went on growing ever weaker.

2 Sons were born to David in Hebron. His firstborn was Amnon,[a] by Ahinoam the Jezreelitess; 3 his second, Chileab,[b] whose mother was Abigail, formerly wife of Nabal of Carmel; and the third, Absalom[c] son of Maacah, daughter of Talmai king of Geshur; 4 the fourth was Adonijah[d] son of Haggith, the fifth Shephatiah[e] son of Abital, 5 and

the sixth Ithream,[f] born to David's wife Eglah. These sons were born to David at Hebron.

6 During the war between Saul's house and David's house, Abner kept strengthening his own position in Saul's house. 7 Now Saul had had a concubine whose name was Rizpah,[g] the daughter of Aiah. And Ish-bosheth[h] said to Abner, "Why have you gone in to my father's concubine?" 8 Then Abner was very angry over the words of Ish-bosheth and said, "Am I a dog's head that belongs to Judah? To this day I keep showing loyalty to the household of your father Saul, to his kinsmen and to his companions, and I have not handed you over into David's hand; and yet you charge me today with a fault concerning this woman! 9 So may God do to Abner and more also, if I do not accomplish for David what Yahweh has sworn to him, 10 to transfer the kingdom from the house of Saul and to set up the throne of David over Israel and over Judah, from Dan to Beersheba." 11 And Ish-bosheth could not answer Abner another word, because he feared him.

12 Abner sent messengers to David on his own behalf[i] to ask, "To whom does the land belong? Make a covenant with me, and I will lend you my support in turning all Israel over to you." 13 "Good," David replied. "I will make a covenant with you, but I demand one thing: you will not be admitted to my presence unless you bring Saul's daughter Michal with you when you come to see me." 14 Then David sent messengers to Ish-bosheth, Saul's son, saying, "Give me my wife Michal, whom I betrothed to myself for a hundred foreskins of the Philistines." 15 So Ish-bosheth had her fetched from her husband, Paltiel son of Laish. 16 But her husband went with her, weeping as he went behind her as far as Bahurim. Then Abner said to him, "Go, return." And he returned.

17 Now Abner had held counsel with Israel's elders, saying, "Both yesterday and the day before you were seeking to have David as king over you. 18 Now then do it. For Yahweh has spoken of David, saying, 'By the hand of my servant David I will save my people Israel from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all their enemies.'" 19 Abner also spoke in the ears of Benjamin. And Abner went to speak in

the ears of David at Hebron all that seemed good to Israel and to the whole house of Benjamin. 20 When Abner came to David at Hebron with twenty men, David made a feast for Abner and the men who were with him. 21 Abner told David, "Let me go at once and gather all Israel to my lord the king, so that they may make a covenant with you and you may rule over everything you desire." David let Abner leave, and he went away in peace.

22 Just then David's servants and Joab came back from a raid, bringing a great deal of plunder. Abner was no longer with David at Hebron, because David had dismissed him and he had left in peace. 23 When Joab and all the army that was with him came, they told Joab, "Abner the son of Ner came to the king, and he has sent him away, and he has gone in peace." 24 Then Joab came to the king and said, "What have you done? Look, Abner came to you. Why is it that you have sent him away, and he is quite gone? 25 You know Abner the son of Ner, that he came to deceive you, and to know your going out and your coming in, and to know all that you are doing." 26 When Joab had gone out from David, he sent messengers after Abner, and they turned him back from the well of Sirah;[j] and David knew nothing of it. 27 When Abner returned to Hebron, Joab took him aside into the midst of the gate to speak with him quietly, and there he smote him in the stomach, and he died, for the blood of Asahel his brother.

28 Afterward, when David heard of it, he said, "I and my kingdom are guiltless before Yahweh forever of the blood of Abner the son of Ner. 29 May it whirl[k] upon the head of Joab and upon all his father's house. And may there never be lacking from the house of Joab one who has a discharge, or one who is leprous,[l] or one who leans on a staff,[m] or one who falls by the sword, or one who lacks bread!" 30 So Joab and Abishai his brother killed Abner, because he had put their brother Asahel to death at Gibeon in the battle.

31 Then David said to Joab and to all the people who were with him, "Tear your clothes, and gird yourselves with sackcloth, and mourn before Abner." And King David followed the bier. 32 They buried Abner in Hebron. And the king lifted up his voice and wept at the grave of Abner, and all the people wept. 33 Then the king chanted a lament

over Abner, and said, “Was Abner to die the death of a fool? 34 Your
hands were not tied, and your feet were not chained. You fell as a man
falls before criminals.” And all the people wept over him once more. 35
Then all the people came to cause David to eat bread while it was yet
day. But David took an oath: “God do so to me, and more as well, if I
taste bread or anything else before sunset!” 36 All the people noticed
this and were pleased; indeed, everything the king did pleased them.
37 So all the people and all Israel understood that day that it had not
been from the king to put to death Abner the son of Ner. 38 And the
king spoke to his servants: “Know you not that a prince and a great
man has fallen this day in Israel? 39 I am weak today, though anointed
king, and these men, the sons of Zeruiah, are too hard for me. May
Yahweh repay the evildoer according to his evil!”[n]

Notes

- a (3:2) Amnon means “faithful.”
- b (3:3) Called Daniel in 1 Chronicles 3:1. The meaning of Chileab is uncertain. The Septuagint reads “Dalouia” (reported).
- c (3:3) Absalom means “my father is peace.” Maacah means “oppression” (uncertain); Talmai perhaps means “furrowed” (uncertain). Geshur was a small Aramean kingdom northeast of the Sea of Galilee.
- d (3:4) Adonijah means “my lord is Yahweh.” Haggith means “festal.”
- e (3:4) Shephatiah means “Yahweh has judged.” The meaning of Abital is “my father is dew” (uncertain).
- f (3:5) Ithream means “remainder of the people” (uncertain). The meaning of Eglah is “heifer.”
- g (3:7) Rizpah means “glowing coal.” Aiah means “falcon.”
- h (3:7) So some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint (Brenton, “Jebosthe the son of Saul”). The traditional Hebrew text lacks the name here.
- i (3:12) Or “where he was.” The Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (3:26) Sirah means “thorn” (uncertain).
- k (3:29) Or “fall.”
- l (3:29) The Hebrew word covered various skin diseases.
- m (3:29) Or “who holds a spindle,” that is, one who is unfit for war (uncertain).
- n (3:39) The Septuagint reads “I am this day a mere kinsman of his, and as it were a subject” (Brenton, modernized). The Hebrew is difficult.

Chapter 4

1 When Saul's son[a] heard that Abner had died in Hebron, his hands
grew feeble, and all Israel was troubled. 2 Now Saul's son had two
men who were captains of raiding bands. The name of the one was
Baanah, and the name of the other Rechab,[b] sons of Rimmon a man
of Beeroth, of the sons of Benjamin (for Beeroth also is reckoned to
Benjamin; 3 the Beerothites fled to Gittaim and have been sojourners
there until this day).
4 Jonathan, Saul's son, had a son who was lame in his feet. He was
five years old when the news about Saul and Jonathan came out of
Jezreel, and his nurse took him up and fled. And as she made haste
to flee, he fell and became lame. His name was Mephibosheth.[c]
5 Then Rechab and Baanah, sons of Rimmon of Beeroth, went off, and
in the heat of the day they reached the house of Ish-bosheth, while
he was lying down for his midday rest. 6 They came there into the
middle of the house as though to fetch wheat, and they struck him in
the belly. Then Rechab and Baanah his brother escaped.[d] 7 When they
came into the house, as he lay on his bed in his bedchamber, they
struck him and killed him and beheaded him. They took his head and
went by the way of the Arabah all night. 8 They carried Ish-bosheth's
head to David in Hebron and said to the king, "Here is the head of
Ish-bosheth son of Saul, your enemy, who sought to kill you. Yahweh
has granted my lord the king revenge today on Saul and his line."
9 But David answered Rechab and Baanah his brother, the sons of
Rimmon the Beerothite, and said to them, "As Yahweh lives, who has
redeemed my soul out of all adversity, 10 when a man told me, 'Saul
is dead,' thinking he was bringing good news, I seized him and killed
him at Ziklag. That was the reward I gave him for his news! 11 How
much more, when wicked men have murdered an innocent man in his
own house, on his own bed, will I demand his blood from your hands
and remove you from the earth!" 12 David gave an order to his young
men, and they killed them, cut off their hands and feet, and hung the
bodies beside the pool at Hebron. But they took Ish-bosheth's head
and buried it in Abner's tomb at Hebron.

Notes

- a (4:1) The Hebrew lacks the name here; the Septuagint reads "Memphibosthe" (reported), but most interpreters understand Ish-bosheth.
- b (4:2) Baanah means "son of affliction" (uncertain). Rechab means "rider." Rimmon means "pomegranate." Beeroth means "wells."
- c (4:4) Mephibosheth means "from the mouth of shame." He is called Merib-baal ("Baal contends" or "the lord is advocate") in 1 Chronicles 8:34; see the note on Ish-bosheth at 2:8.
- d (4:6) The Septuagint reads differently: "And behold, the porter of the house was winnowing wheat, and she slumbered and slept, and the brothers Rechab and Baanah slipped into the house" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 5

1 Then all the tribes of Israel came to David at Hebron and spoke, saying, "See, we are your bone and your flesh. 2 Even in time past, when Saul was king over us, it was you who led Israel out and brought Israel in. And Yahweh said to you, 'You shall shepherd my people Israel, and you shall be prince over Israel.'" 3 When all the elders of Israel had come to the king at Hebron, King David made a covenant with them there in Yahweh's presence, and they anointed David as king over Israel. 4 Thirty years old was David at his becoming king, and forty years he reigned. 5 In Hebron he reigned over Judah seven years and six months, and in Jerusalem he reigned thirty-three years over all Israel and Judah.

6 The king and his men went to Jerusalem against the Jebusites, the people living in that land. They told David, "You will never get in here; even the blind and the lame can turn you back," thinking, "David cannot enter." 7 Nevertheless David captured the stronghold of Zion,[a] which is the City of David. 8 That day David said, "Anyone who wants to defeat the Jebusites should get up through the water shaft[b] to attack those 'lame and blind' whom David hates." This is why people say, "The blind and the lame may not enter the house." 9 David dwelt in the stronghold and called it the City of David. And David built round about from the Millo[c] inward. 10 And David went on and grew great, for Yahweh God of Armies was with him.

11 Hiram[d] king of Tyre sent messengers to David, and cedar trees, and carpenters and masons,[e] and they built David a house. 12 And David

perceived that Yahweh had established him king over Israel, and that he had exalted his kingdom for the sake of his people Israel.
13 David took more concubines and wives out of Jerusalem after he came from Hebron, and more sons and daughters were born to David. 14 These are the names of those born to him in Jerusalem: Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, Solomon,[f] 15 Ibhar, Elishua, Nepheg, Japhia, 16 Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet.[g]
17 When the Philistines heard that they had anointed David king over Israel, all the Philistines went up to seek David. David heard of it and went down to the stronghold. 18 The Philistines had come and spread out across the Valley of Rephaim.[h] 19 And David inquired of Yahweh, "Shall I go up against the Philistines? Will you give them into my hand?" Yahweh said to David, "Go up, for I will surely give the Philistines into your hand." 20 So David came to Baal-perazim, and David struck them there. And he said, "Yahweh has broken through my enemies before me, like a breaking through of waters." Therefore he called the name of that place Baal-perazim.[i] 21 They abandoned their idols there, and David and his men carried them away.[j]
22 Yet again the Philistines came up and spread themselves out in the Valley of Rephaim. 23 When David inquired of Yahweh, he said, "You shall not go up. Circle around behind them, and come upon them opposite the balsam trees.[k] 24 And when you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the balsam trees, then bestir yourself, for then Yahweh has gone out before you to strike the camp of the Philistines." 25 And David did so, as Yahweh had commanded him, and struck the Philistines from Geba[l] all the way to Gezer.

Notes

- a (5:7) Zion was the fortified hill of the Jebusite city, the southeastern ridge of Jerusalem. The meaning of the name is uncertain.
- b (5:8) The Hebrew word tsinnor is uncertain; perhaps "water shaft" or "channel," or a kind of hook or weapon (scholarly review). The Septuagint reads "let him attack with the dagger" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (5:9) Millo means "filling," probably a terraced earthwork.
- d (5:11) Hiram means "my brother is exalted" (uncertain).
- e (5:11) Hebrew "craftsmen of wood and craftsmen of stone for walls."

- f (5:14) Shammua means “heard.” Shobab perhaps means “returning” (uncertain). Nathan means “he has given.” Solomon is related to the word for “peace.”
- g (5:16) Ibhar means “he chooses.” Elishua means “God is salvation.” Nepheg perhaps means “sprout” (uncertain). Japhia means “he shines forth.” Elishama means “God has heard.” Eliada means “God knows.” Eliphelet means “God is deliverance.”
- h (5:18) Rephaim means “ghosts” or the name of an ancient people of great stature; the valley lay southwest of Jerusalem.
- i (5:20) Baal-perazim means “lord of breaking through.”
- j (5:21) First Chronicles 14:12 adds that they were burned.
- k (5:23) Or “baka shrubs”; the exact kind of tree is uncertain. Likewise in verse 24.
- l (5:25) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint and 1 Chronicles 14:16 read “Gibeon” (reported).

Chapter 6

1 David again gathered all the chosen men of Israel, thirty thousand.
2 And David arose and went with all the people who were with him
from Baale-judah,[a] to bring up from there the ark of God, which
is called by the name, the name of Yahweh of Armies, who sits
enthroned on the cherubim. 3 They placed the ark of God upon a
new wagon and brought it out from Abinadab’s house on the hill;
and Uzzah and Ahio,[b] Abinadab’s sons, drove the new wagon, 4 with
the ark of God;[c] and Ahio went before the ark. 5 David and all the
house of Israel were making merry before Yahweh with all kinds of
instruments of fir wood,[d] with lyres and harps and tambourines and
rattles and cymbals.
6 They came to the threshing floor of Nacon,[e] and because the oxen
had stumbled, Uzzah put out his hand and took hold of the ark of
God. 7 And the anger of Yahweh was kindled against Uzzah, and God
struck him there for his error,[f] and he died there beside the ark of God.
8 David was angry because Yahweh had broken out against Uzzah.
And he called that place Perez-uzzah,[g] as it is named to this day. 9
David was afraid of Yahweh that day, and he said, “How can the ark
of Yahweh come to me?” 10 So David would not take the ark of Yahweh
to himself into the City of David, but David turned it aside to the
house of Obed-edom[h] the Gittite. 11 The ark of Yahweh remained in the
house of Obed-edom the Gittite three months, and Yahweh blessed
Obed-edom and all his household.

12 News came to King David: "Yahweh has blessed the household of
Obed-edom, with all that he has, on account of the ark of God." So
David went and had the ark of God brought up from Obed-edom's
house into the City of David with joy. 13 When those who carried the
ark of Yahweh had gone six paces, he sacrificed an ox and a fattened
animal. 14 And David danced before Yahweh with all his might, and
David was girded with a linen ephod. 15 So David and all the house
of Israel brought up the ark of Yahweh with shouting and with the
sound of the horn.
16 As the ark of Yahweh came into the City of David, Michal the
daughter of Saul looked out through the window and saw King David
leaping and whirling before Yahweh, and she despised him in her
heart. 17 They brought in the ark of Yahweh and set it in its place,
inside the tent that David had pitched for it. And David offered burnt
offerings and peace offerings before Yahweh. 18 When David had
made an end of offering the burnt offerings and the peace offerings,
he blessed the people in the name of Yahweh of Armies. 19 And he
apportioned to all the people, to the whole throng of Israel, to man
and to woman, one loaf of bread apiece, a cake of dates,[i] and a cake
of raisins. Then all the people departed, each to his house.
20 When David went home to bless his household, Saul's daughter
Michal came out to meet him. "How splendid the king of Israel looked
today," she said, "exposing himself before his servants' slave girls,
the way some vulgar person would expose himself!" 21 David said to
Michal, "It was before Yahweh, who chose me above your father and
above all his house, to appoint me prince over the people of Yahweh,
over Israel; and I will make merry before Yahweh. 22 I will make myself
yet more lightly esteemed than this, and I will be lowly in my own
eyes.[j] But with the maids you speak of, with them I shall have honor."
23 And Michal the daughter of Saul had no child to the day of her death.

Notes

- a (6:2) Baale-judah means "lords of Judah," another name for Kiriath-jearim (1 Chronicles 13:6; Joshua 15:9). Some Hebrew manuscripts and other witnesses reportedly read "Baalah of Judah."

- b (6:3) Uzzah means “strength.” Ahio means “his brother” (uncertain); the Septuagint reads “his brothers” (reported).
- c (6:4) The Hebrew repeats part of verse 3 here: “and they carried it out of the house of Abinadab, which was on the hill, with the ark of God.” The Septuagint has a shorter text (reported).
- d (6:5) So the traditional Hebrew text, literally “with all woods of cypress.” The Septuagint and 1 Chronicles 13:8 read “with all their might and with songs” (Brenton, “on well-tuned instruments mightily, and with songs,” modernized).
- e (6:6) Nacon means “prepared” (uncertain). First Chronicles 13:9 reads “Chidon.” The Septuagint reads “Nachor” (Brenton).
- f (6:7) The Hebrew word is uncertain. First Chronicles 13:10 reads “because he put out his hand to the ark.”
- g (6:8) Perez-uzzah means “breaking out against Uzzah.”
- h (6:10) Obed-edom means “servant of Edom” (uncertain).
- i (6:19) The Hebrew word is uncertain; perhaps “a portion of meat.” The Septuagint reads “a joint of meat” (Brenton).
- j (6:22) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint reads “in your eyes” (reported).

Chapter 7

1 Now it came to pass, when the king lived in his house and Yahweh
had given him rest from all his enemies round about, 2 that the king
said to Nathan the prophet, “See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but
the ark of God dwells within curtains.” 3 And Nathan said to the king,
“Go, do all that is in your heart, for Yahweh is with you.”
4 But that same night the word of Yahweh came to Nathan, saying, 5
“Go and tell my servant David, ‘Thus says Yahweh: Would you build
me a house for me to dwell in? 6 For I have not dwelt in a house from
the day I brought the sons of Israel up out of Egypt even until this
day, but I have gone about in a tent and in a tabernacle. 7 In all places
where I have walked with all the sons of Israel, did I speak a word
with any of the tribes[a] of Israel, whom I commanded to shepherd my
people Israel, saying, “Why have you not built me a house of cedar?”’
8 Now then, speak thus to my servant David: ‘So says Yahweh of
Armies: From the sheepfold I took you, from behind the flock, that
you should be prince over my people, over Israel. 9 I have been with
you wherever you went and have cut off all your enemies from your
presence. And I will make you a great name, like the name of the great
ones who are on the earth. 10 And I will appoint a place for my people

Israel and will plant them, that they may dwell in their own place and be troubled no more. And the sons of wickedness shall afflict them no more, as at the first, 11 from the day that I commanded judges to be over my people Israel. And I will give you rest from all your enemies. Moreover, Yahweh declares to you that Yahweh will make you a house.[b] 12 When your days are complete and you sleep with your fathers, I will raise up your seed after you, which shall proceed out of your bowels, and I will make his kingdom firm. 13 He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. 14 I will be his father, and he shall be my son. If he does wrong, I will correct him with the rod of men and with the blows of the sons of Adam, 15 but my steadfast love shall not depart from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you. 16 Your house and your kingdom will be secure forever before you.[c] Your throne will last for all time.'" 17 According to all these words and according to all this vision, so Nathan spoke to David.

18 Then King David went in and sat before Yahweh and said, "Who am I, Lord Yahweh, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far? 19 And yet this was a small thing in your eyes, Lord Yahweh. You have spoken also of your servant's house for a great while to come, and this is the instruction for mankind,[d] Lord Yahweh! 20 And what more can David say to you? For you know your servant, Lord Yahweh! 21 Because of your word, and according to your own heart, you have done all this greatness, to make your servant know it. 22 Therefore you are great, Lord Yahweh. For there is none like you, and there is no God besides you, according to all that we have heard with our ears. 23 Is there another nation on earth like your people Israel, whom God went out to redeem for himself as a people, to win a name for himself, and to perform great and awesome acts for them,[e] by driving out nations and their gods ahead of your people, whom you redeemed for yourself from Egypt? 24 And you established for yourself your people Israel to be your people forever, and you, Yahweh, became their God.

25 And now, Yahweh God, the word that you have spoken concerning your servant and concerning his house, confirm it forever, and do as

you have spoken. 26 May your name be great forever, so that people say, 'Yahweh of Armies is God over Israel,' and may your servant David's house be established in your presence. 27 For you, Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, have revealed to your servant, saying, 'I will build you a house.' Therefore your servant has found courage[f] to pray this prayer to you. 28 And now, Lord Yahweh, you are God, and your words are truth, and you have promised this good thing to your servant. 29 Please be pleased now to bless your servant's house so that it continues in your presence forever. You, Lord Yahweh, have spoken, and by your blessing your servant's house will be blessed forever."

Notes

- a (7:7) So the Hebrew, shivte. First Chronicles 17:6 reads "judges" (shofte), a very similar word.
- b (7:11) That is, a royal dynasty. The Septuagint reads "and the Lord will tell you that you shall build a house to him" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (7:16) So the Hebrew. Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint read "before me" (reported).
- d (7:19) The Hebrew is obscure, literally "and this is the law of man." First Chronicles 17:17 reads differently.
- e (7:23) The Hebrew is difficult, literally "for you," "for your land"; compare 1 Chronicles 17:21 and the Septuagint (Brenton, "to do mightily and nobly, so that you should cast out nations and their tabernacles," modernized).
- f (7:27) Literally "found his heart."

Chapter 8

1 Some time later David defeated the Philistines and brought them under control, and he took Metheg-ammah[a] from Philistine hands. 2 He also defeated Moab. He made the people lie on the ground and measured them off with a cord: two cord-lengths of them to be put to death and one full length to be spared. So the Moabites became David's subjects and paid him tribute.

3 David also defeated Hadadezer[b] son of Rehob, king of Zobah, when Hadadezer went to restore his control[c] along the Euphrates River. 4 David captured from him 1,700 horsemen[d] and 20,000 foot soldiers. He crippled all but a hundred of the chariot horses, keeping only enough for a hundred chariots. 5 When the Arameans[e] of Damascus

came to help Hadadezer king of Zobah, David struck down twenty-two thousand men of the Arameans. 6 Then David put garrisons in Aram of Damascus, and the Arameans became David's servants, bringing tribute. Yahweh gave David victory everywhere he went. 7 David took the shields of gold that were on the servants of Hadadezer and brought them to Jerusalem.[f] 8 From Betah and Berothai,[g] cities belonging to Hadadezer, King David carried off a huge amount of bronze.[h]

9 When Toi[i] king of Hamath heard that David had struck all the army of Hadadezer, 10 Toi sent Joram[j] his son to King David to ask after his welfare and to bless him, because he had fought against Hadadezer and struck him; for Hadadezer had often been at war with Toi. And in his hand were vessels of silver and vessels of gold and vessels of bronze. 11 These also King David set apart to Yahweh, with the silver and the gold that he had set apart from every nation that he brought under, 12 from Aram,[k] from Moab, from the Ammonites, from the Philistines, from Amalek, and out of the plunder of Hadadezer son of Rehob, king of Zobah. 13 And David made a name for himself when he returned from striking down the Arameans[l] in the Valley of Salt, eighteen thousand men. 14 He stationed garrisons throughout Edom, and all the Edomites became David's subjects. Yahweh gave David victory everywhere he went.

15 So David reigned over all Israel, and David executed justice and righteousness for all his people. 16 Joab the son of Zeruiah was over the army, and Jehoshaphat[m] the son of Ahilud was recorder, 17 and Zadok the son of Ahitub and Ahimelech the son of Abiathar[n] were priests, and Seraiah[o] was secretary, 18 and Benaiah[p] the son of Jehoiada was over the Cherethites and the Pelethites,[q] and David's sons were priests.[r]

Notes

- a (8:1) Metheg-ammah means "bridle of the mother city" (uncertain); 1 Chronicles 18:1 reads "Gath and its villages."
- b (8:3) Hadadezer means "Hadad is help"; Hadad was the Aramean storm god.
- c (8:3) Literally "his hand," that is, his control or a monument (uncertain).
- d (8:4) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint and 1 Chronicles 18:4 read "a thousand chariots and seven thousand horsemen" (Brenton, modernized).

- e (8:5) Hebrew "Aram" and "Arameans" (Syrians). Likewise throughout.
- f (8:7) Or "golden quivers" (uncertain). The Septuagint reads "golden bracelets" and adds, "And Susakim king of Egypt took them, when he went up to Jerusalem in the days of Rehoboam son of Solomon" (Brenton, modernized).
- g (8:8) Betah is called Tibhath in 1 Chronicles 18:8; the Septuagint reads "Metebac" (Brenton). Berothai means "my wells" (uncertain).
- h (8:8) The Septuagint adds "with that Solomon made the bronze sea, and the pillars, and the basins, and all the furnishings" (Brenton, modernized; compare 1 Chronicles 18:8).
- i (8:9) Called Tou in 1 Chronicles 18:9. The meaning of the name is uncertain.
- j (8:10) Joram means "Yahweh is exalted." First Chronicles 18:10 reads "Hadoram."
- k (8:12) So the Hebrew. Some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint (Brenton, "out of Idumea"), and 1 Chronicles 18:11 read "Edom," a word very similar in Hebrew.
- l (8:13) So the Hebrew. Some Hebrew manuscripts and 1 Chronicles 18:12 read "Edomites"; the Septuagint reads "he smote Idumea" (Brenton). See verse 14.
- m (8:16) Jehoshaphat means "Yahweh has judged."
- n (8:17) So the Hebrew. The Syriac reportedly reads "Abiathar son of Ahimelech" (compare 1 Samuel 22:20). Zadok means "righteous."
- o (8:17) Seraiah means "Yahweh has prevailed" (uncertain). He is called Shavsha in 1 Chronicles 18:16.
- p (8:18) Benaiah means "Yahweh has built." Jehoiada means "Yahweh knows."
- q (8:18) The Cherethites and Pelethites were royal guards, perhaps from Crete and Philistia.
- r (8:18) Hebrew kohanim, the usual word for priests. First Chronicles 18:17 reads "chief officials at the king's side"; the Septuagint reads "princes of the court" (Brenton).

Chapter 9

1 And David said, "Is there yet any who is left of the house of Saul, that
I may show him kindness for Jonathan's sake?" 2 There was a servant
of Saul's household named Ziba,[a] and he was summoned to David.
"Are you Ziba?" the king asked. "At your service," he answered. 3
The king asked, "Is there no one left of Saul's house to whom I may
show God's kindness?" Ziba told the king, "A son of Jonathan is
still alive; he is lame in both feet." 4 The king said to him, "Where
is he?" Ziba said to the king, "Look, he is in the house of Machir[b]
the son of Ammiel, at Lo-debar."[c] 5 Then King David sent and fetched
him from the house of Machir the son of Ammiel, from Lo-debar. 6
Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, came to David

and fell on his face and did obeisance. David said, “Mephibosheth!” And he answered, “Here is your servant!” 7 David said to him, “Fear not, for I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father’s sake, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat bread at my table continually.” 8 Mephibosheth bowed and said, “What is your servant, that you take notice of a dead dog like me?”

9 Then the king called to Ziba, Saul’s servant, and said to him, “All that belonged to Saul and to all his house I have given to your master’s son. 10 You are to farm the land for him, you and your sons and your servants, and bring in the produce, so that your master’s son will have food to eat. But Mephibosheth, your master’s son, will always eat at my table.” Ziba had fifteen sons and twenty servants. 11 Ziba told the king, “Your servant will do all that my lord the king commands.” “And Mephibosheth ate at my[d] table like one of the king’s sons.” 12 Mephibosheth had a young son whose name was Mica.[e] And all who dwelt in the house of Ziba were servants to Mephibosheth. 13 So Mephibosheth dwelt in Jerusalem, for he ate continually at the king’s table. And he was lame in both his feet.

Notes

- a (9:2) Ziba perhaps means “plant” or “strength” (uncertain).
- b (9:4) Machir means “sold.” Ammiel means “my kinsman is God.”
- c (9:4) Lo-debar means “no pasture” or “no thing” (uncertain), a town east of the Jordan.
- d (9:11) So the Hebrew; the words may be the king’s. The Septuagint reads “at the table of David” (Brenton).
- e (9:12) Mica means “who is like?” (short for “who is like Yahweh?”).

Chapter 10

1 Some time later the king of the Ammonites died, and his son Hanun[a] became king in his place. 2 David said, “I will be kind to Hanun son of Nahash, just as his father was kind to me.” So David sent a delegation of his servants to console him over his father. When David’s servants reached the land of the Ammonites, 3 But the Ammonite commanders told their lord Hanun, “Is David really honoring your father, in your opinion, by sending men to console you? Has David not rather sent

his servants to you to explore the city, spy on it, and overthrow it?" 4 So Hanun seized David's servants and shaved away one half of their beards, and he cut away their robes at the middle, up to their hips, and sent them off. 5 When they told it to David, he sent to meet them, for the men were greatly ashamed. And the king said, "Stay at Jericho until your beards have grown, and then return."

6 When the Ammonites realized that they had become hateful to David, they hired 20,000 Aramean foot soldiers from Beth-rehob and Zobah, 1,000 men from the king of Maacah, and 12,000 men from Tob.[b] 7 When David heard of it, he sent Joab and all the host of the mighty men. 8 The Ammonites marched out and took up battle positions at the city gate, while the Arameans of Zobah and Rehob and the men of Tob and Maacah took up positions separately in the open country. 9 When Joab saw that the battle was set against him both in front and behind, he chose some of all the choice men of Israel and arrayed them against the Arameans. 10 He put the rest of the troops under his brother Abishai, who drew them up in formation against the Ammonites. 11 Joab said, "If the Arameans prove too strong for me, you are to come to my aid; and if the Ammonites prove too strong for you, I will come to yours. 12 Be strong, and let us play the man for our people and for the cities of our God. And may Yahweh do what is good in his eyes." 13 So Joab and the people who were with him drew near to battle against the Arameans, and they fled before him. 14 When the Ammonites saw the Arameans flee, they too fled from Abishai and retreated into the city. Joab then left the battle with the Ammonites and returned to Jerusalem.

15 When the Arameans saw that they had been beaten before Israel, they gathered themselves together. 16 Hadadezer sent for the Arameans from across the River,[c] and they came to Helam,[d] led by Shobach, the commander of Hadadezer's army. 17 David was told, so he mustered all Israel, crossed the Jordan, and went to Helam. The Arameans lined up to meet David and fought against him. 18 And the Arameans fled before Israel, and David killed of the Arameans the men of seven hundred chariots and forty thousand horsemen,[e] and he struck Shobach the captain of their army, so that he died there.

19 When all the kings who served Hadadezer saw they had been defeated by Israel, they came to terms with Israel and served them. And the Arameans were afraid to give the Ammonites any more help.

Notes

- a (10:1) Hanun means "favored."
- b (10:6) Or "the men of Ish-tob." Tob means "good." The Septuagint reads "Istob" (Brenton) and "the king of Amalek" for "the king of Maacah." Beth-rehob means "house of the broad place."
- c (10:16) That is, the Euphrates.
- d (10:16) Helam was east of the Jordan; its location is uncertain.
- e (10:18) First Chronicles 19:18 reads "seven thousand charioteers and forty thousand foot soldiers." The Septuagint here agrees with the Hebrew (Brenton).

Chapter 11

1 Now it came to pass at the return of the year, at the time when kings go out to battle,[a] that David sent Joab and his servants with him and all Israel, and they ravaged the sons of Ammon and besieged Rabbah.[b] But David remained in Jerusalem.

2 It happened, at the time of evening, that David arose from his couch and walked about on the roof of the king's house. And from the roof he saw a woman bathing, and the woman was very fair to look upon. 3 David sent and inquired about the woman. And one said, "Is not this Bathsheba,[c] the daughter of Eliam,[d] the wife of Uriah the Hittite?"[e] 4 So David sent messengers and took her, and she came in to him, and he lay with her. (She was cleansing herself from her impurity.) Then she went back to her house. 5 The woman conceived, and she sent and told David, and said, "I am with child."

6 Then David sent to Joab, "Send me Uriah the Hittite." And Joab sent Uriah to David. 7 When Uriah had come to him, David asked how Joab was faring and how the people fared and how the war went. 8 David told Uriah, "Go home and wash your feet." Uriah left the palace, and a gift from the king followed him. 9 But Uriah slept at the door of the king's house with all the servants of his lord, and did not go down to his house. 10 So they reported to David, "Uriah went not down to his house." And David asked Uriah, "Is it not from a journey that you come? For what reason did you not go down to your house?" 11 Uriah

said to David, "The ark and Israel and Judah are dwelling in booths, and my lord Joab and the servants of my lord are camped in the open field. Shall I then go into my house, to eat and to drink and to lie with my wife? By your life, and by the life of your soul, I will not do this thing." 12 Then David said to Uriah, "Stay here today also, and tomorrow I will send you away." So Uriah remained in Jerusalem that day and the next. 13 David invited him, and Uriah ate and drank in his presence, and David made him drunk. Yet that evening he went out and slept on his bed with his lord's servants; he never went down to his own house.

14 In the morning David wrote a letter to Joab and sent it by the hand of Uriah. 15 In it he wrote, "Put Uriah at the front, where the fighting is fiercest, then pull back from him so that he will be struck down and die." 16 So as Joab was keeping watch on the city, he assigned Uriah to the place where he knew that valiant men were. 17 And the men of the city came out and fought with Joab, and some of the people of David's servants fell. Uriah the Hittite died also.

18 Then Joab sent and told David all the things concerning the war. 19 And he charged the messenger, saying, "When you have finished telling all the matters of the war to the king, 20 then if the king's anger flares up, and he says to you, 'For what reason did you approach so close to the city to fight? Did you not know they would shoot from upon the wall? 21 Who killed Abimelech son of Jerubbesheth?[f] Did not a woman drop an upper millstone on him from the wall, so that he died at Thebez? Why did you venture near the wall?' then you are to say, 'Your servant Uriah the Hittite is also dead.'"

22 So the messenger departed, and he came and reported to David everything for which Joab had sent him.[g] 23 The messenger said to David, "The men prevailed against us and came out against us into the field, but we drove them back to the entrance of the gate. 24 Then the archers shot at your servants from the wall. Some of the king's servants are dead, and your servant Uriah the Hittite is dead also." 25 David told the messenger, "Tell Joab this: 'Do not let this matter upset you, for the sword devours one person and then another. Press your attack on the city and destroy it.' Give him courage."

26 When the wife of Uriah heard that Uriah her husband was dead,
she mourned for her husband. 27 And when the mourning was past,
David sent and gathered her into his house, and she became his wife
and bore him a son. But the thing that David had done was evil in the
eyes of Yahweh.

Notes

- a (11:1) Literally "at the return of the year," that is, in the spring. So many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint (Brenton, "when the time of the year for kings going out to battle had come round"), and 1 Chronicles 20:1. The traditional Hebrew text reads "messengers" (mal'akhim) for "kings" (melakhim).
- b (11:1) Rabbah means "great (city)," the Ammonite capital, modern Amman.
- c (11:3) Bathsheba means "daughter of an oath" or "daughter of seven." She is called Bath-shua in 1 Chronicles 3:5.
- d (11:3) Eliam means "God is my kinsman." He is called Ammiel in 1 Chronicles 3:5.
- e (11:3) Uriah means "Yahweh is my light."
- f (11:21) That is, Jerubbaal, Gideon (Judges 6:32; 9:50–54); compare the note on Ish-bosheth at 2:8. The Septuagint reads "Jerobaal son of Ner" (Brenton).
- g (11:22) The Septuagint adds a longer form of David's angry questions, repeating those of verses 20–21 (Brenton).

Chapter 12

1 And Yahweh sent Nathan to David. He came to him and said to him,
"There were two men in one city, the one rich and the other poor. 2
The rich man had flocks and herds in great abundance; 3 but the poor
man had nothing except one little ewe lamb, which he had bought and
kept alive. And it grew up with him and with his children together.
It would eat of his own morsel and drink from his own cup and lie in
his bosom, and it was to him as a daughter. 4 Now a traveler arrived
at the rich man's house, and the rich man was unwilling to take an
animal from his own flock or herd to cook a meal for the visitor who
had come to him. He took the poor man's lamb instead and prepared
it for his guest." 5 Then David's anger was greatly kindled against the
man, and he said to Nathan, "As Yahweh lives, the man who did this
is a son of death![a] 6 And he shall restore the lamb fourfold,[b] because
he did this thing and because he had no pity."
7 Nathan said to David, "You are the man! This is what Yahweh, the
God of Israel, says: 'I anointed you king over Israel, and I rescued

you from Saul's hand. 8 I gave you your master's house and your master's wives into your bosom, and gave you the house of Israel and of Judah. And if that had been too little, I would have added to you as much again. 9 Why have you despised Yahweh's word,[c] doing what is evil in his sight? You killed Uriah the Hittite with the sword and took his wife as your own; you murdered him with the sword of the Ammonites. 10 Now therefore the sword shall never depart from your house, because you have despised me and have taken the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be your wife.' 11 This is what Yahweh says: 'I will bring trouble on you from your own household. Before your eyes I will take your wives and give them to another man, and he will sleep with them in broad daylight. 12 For you did it secretly, but I will do this thing before all Israel and before the sun.'" 13 David said to Nathan, "I have sinned against Yahweh." And Nathan said to David, "Yahweh also has put away your sin; you shall not die. 14 Nevertheless, because by this deed you have utterly scorned the enemies of Yahweh,[d] the child also who is born to you shall surely die." 15 Then Nathan went to his house. And Yahweh struck the child that Uriah's wife bore to David, and it became very sick. 16 David therefore sought God for the child. And David fasted and went in and lay all night on the ground. 17 The elders of his house stood beside him to raise him up from the ground, but he was not willing, and he ate no bread with them. 18 On the seventh day the child died. David's servants were afraid to tell him that the child was dead, for they said, "While the child was still alive, we spoke to him and he paid no attention to our voice. How can we tell him that the child is dead? He may do himself harm." 19 But when David saw that his servants were whispering together, David perceived that the child was dead. And David said to his servants, "Is the child dead?" They said, "He is dead." 20 David got up from the ground, washed, anointed himself, and changed his clothes. He went into Yahweh's house and worshiped. Then he went home, asked for food, and they set it before him, and he ate. 21 His servants said to him, "What is this you are doing? You fasted and wept for the child while he was still living, yet when the child died you got up and ate food." 22 He said, "While the child was yet alive, I fasted and wept, for I said,

‘Who knows whether Yahweh will be gracious to me, that the child
may live?’ 23 But now he is dead. Why should I fast? Can I bring him
back again? I shall go to him, but he will not return to me.”
24 Then David comforted Bathsheba his wife, and went in to her and
lay with her, and she bore a son, and he called his name Solomon.[e]
And Yahweh loved him 25 and sent by the hand of Nathan the prophet,
and he called his name Jedidiah,[f] because of Yahweh.
26 Now Joab fought against Rabbah of the sons of Ammon and took
the royal city. 27 Joab sent messengers to David with the message,
“I have fought against Rabbah and captured the water city.[g] 28 Now
therefore gather the rest of the people together and encamp against
the city and take it, lest I take the city and my name be called over it.”
29 So David gathered all the people together and went to Rabbah and
fought against it and took it. 30 He took the crown of their king[h] from
his head. Its weight was about seventy-five pounds[i] of gold, with a
precious stone, and it was set on David’s head. And he brought out
the spoil of the city, a very great amount. 31 And the people that were
in it he brought forth and set them at saws and at sledges of iron and
at axes of iron, and made them toil in the brickworks.[j] So he dealt
with every city of the sons of Ammon. And David returned with all
the people to Jerusalem.

Notes

- a (12:5) That is, deserves to die.
- b (12:6) So the Hebrew (compare Exodus 22:1). The Septuagint reads “seven-fold” (reported).
- c (12:9) Some Septuagint manuscripts read “despised Yahweh” (reported); compare verse 10.
- d (12:14) The Hebrew includes “the enemies of,” probably as a scribal softening to avoid saying David scorned Yahweh himself. The Septuagint reads the same (Brenton, “given great occasion of provocation to the enemies of the Lord”).
- e (12:24) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads “she called.”
- f (12:25) Jedidiah means “beloved of Yahweh.” The Septuagint reads “Jeddedi” (Brenton).
- g (12:27) That is, the part of the city that controlled the water supply.
- h (12:30) Or “of Milcom,” the Ammonite god (1 Kings 11:5); the Hebrew malkam can be read either way. The Septuagint reads “Molchom their king” (Brenton).
- i (12:30) Hebrew “a talent,” about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).

- j (12:31) So the traditional reading (qere), describing forced labor. The written text (ketiv) reads “made them pass through Malkan,” perhaps a reference to Molech worship (uncertain). The Septuagint reads “put them under the saw … and made them pass through the brick kiln” (Brenton, modernized), which some understand as execution (scholarly review).

Chapter 13

1 Now after this it came to pass that Absalom the son of David had
a fair sister whose name was Tamar.[a] And Amnon the son of David
loved her. 2 Amnon became so tormented over his sister Tamar that he
fell ill, for she was a virgin, and it seemed out of reach for Amnon to
do anything to her. 3 But Amnon had a friend whose name was Jon-
adab,[b] the son of Shimeah, David’s brother. And Jonadab was a very
shrewd man. 4 He said to him, “Why are you so lean from morning
to morning, son of the king? Will you not tell me?” Amnon said to
him, “I love Tamar, the sister of Absalom my brother.” 5 Jonadab said
to him, “Lay yourself upon your bed and make yourself sick. When
your father comes in to look on you, tell him, ‘Pray, let Tamar my
sister come and feed me with bread, and let her make the dish before
my eyes, so that I may watch and eat from her hand.’” 6 So Amnon lay
down and feigned sickness. And the king came in to look on him, and
Amnon said to the king, “Pray, let Tamar my sister come and make a
couple of cakes before my eyes, that I may eat from her hand.”
7 Then David sent home to Tamar, saying, “Go now to your brother
Amnon’s house and prepare food for him.” 8 So Tamar went to the
house of Amnon her brother, and he was lying in bed. And she took
dough and kneaded it and made cakes in his sight and baked the
cakes. 9 And she took the pan and poured them out before him, but
he refused to eat. And Amnon said, “Send everyone out from me.” So
everyone went out from him. 10 Then Amnon said to Tamar, “Bring
the food into the chamber, that I may eat from your hand.” And Tamar
took the cakes she had made and brought them into the chamber to
Amnon her brother. 11 But when she brought them near to him to eat,
he took hold of her and said to her, “Come, lie with me, my sister.”
12 “No, my brother,” she answered, “do not force me, because such a
thing is never done in Israel. Do not commit this disgrace.[c] 13 As for

me, where would I take my disgrace? And you would be counted as one of the fools in Israel. Please, speak to the king; he will not refuse me to you." 14 But he would not listen to her voice. Being stronger than she, he forced her and lay with her.

15 Then Amnon was seized by a hatred of her so intense that it was stronger than the love he had felt for her. "Get up and leave!" he told her. 16 But she said to him, "No, for this wrong in sending me away is greater than the other that you did to me."[d] But he would not listen to her. 17 Then he summoned the lad who attended him and said, "Send this one away from me, out of doors, and fasten the door behind her." 18 She had on her a long-sleeved tunic,[e] for in such robes the king's daughters who were virgins were dressed. So his attendant put her outside and fastened the door behind her. 19 And Tamar put ashes on her head and rent the long-sleeved tunic that was on her. And she put her hand upon her head and went off, crying out as she walked. 20 Her brother Absalom said to her, "Has your brother Amnon[f] been with you? Keep quiet now, my sister; he is your brother. Do not let this weigh on your heart." And Tamar stayed in her brother Absalom's house, a desolate woman.

21 When King David heard of all these things, he was very angry.[g] 22 But Absalom spoke to Amnon neither good nor bad, for Absalom hated Amnon, because he had humbled his sister Tamar.

23 Two whole years later, Absalom held a sheep-shearing in Baal-hazor near Ephraim, and he called all the sons of the king. 24 Absalom came to the king and said, "See now, your servant has sheepshearers. Let the king, I pray, and his servants go with your servant." 25 The king said to Absalom, "No, my son, let us not all go now, lest we be burdensome to you." He pressed him, but he would not go, though he blessed him. 26 Then Absalom said, "If not, please let my brother Amnon go with us." And the king said to him, "Why should he go with you?" 27 But Absalom kept urging him, until he let Amnon and all the king's sons go with him.[h] 28 Then Absalom commanded his young men, saying, "Mark now, when Amnon's heart is merry with wine, and I say to you, 'Strike Amnon,' then kill him. Do not fear. Have not I commanded you? Be courageous and be valiant." 29 So the young men

of Absalom did to Amnon as Absalom had commanded. Then all the king's sons arose, and each man mounted his mule and fled.
30 While they were on the road, the tidings reached David: "Absalom has slain every one of the king's sons, and there is not one of them left." 31 Then the king arose and tore his garments and lay on the earth. And all his servants stood by with their clothes torn. 32 But Jonadab son of Shimeah, David's brother, spoke up: "My lord should not think they have killed all the young princes; only Amnon is dead. This has been Absalom's intention[i] ever since the day Amnon violated his sister Tamar. 33 Now therefore let not my lord the king take the thing to his heart, to think that all the king's sons are dead; for Amnon alone is dead."
34 But Absalom fled. And the young man who kept the watch lifted up his eyes and looked, and look, a great company was approaching on the road behind him[j] along the hillside. 35 Jonadab said to the king, "See, the king's sons are coming. According to your servant's word, so it has come to be." 36 As soon as he had finished speaking, look, the king's sons came and lifted up their voice and wept. And the king also and all his servants wept very bitterly. 37 But Absalom fled and went to Talmai the son of Ammihud,[k] king of Geshur. And David mourned for his son day after day. 38 So Absalom fled and went to Geshur, and was there three years. 39 King David's spirit longed to go out[l] to Absalom, for he had been consoled about Amnon's death.

Notes

- a (13:1) Tamar means "palm tree."
- b (13:3) Jonadab means "Yahweh is generous." Shimeah is called Shammah in 1 Samuel 16:9 and Shimea in 1 Chronicles 2:13.
- c (13:12) Hebrew nevalah, a word for gross folly or sacrilege; compare verse 13, "fools" (nevalim).
- d (13:16) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- e (13:18) Or "a robe reaching to the palms and soles" (uncertain); the same phrase describes Joseph's robe (Genesis 37:3).
- f (13:20) Hebrew "Aminon," perhaps a diminutive or a scornful form.
- g (13:21) The Septuagint adds a sentence saying that David did not grieve his son Amnon's spirit, since he loved him as his firstborn (Brenton, modernized). 4QSam-a reportedly contains the same addition.

- h (13:27) The Septuagint adds “and Absalom made a banquet like the banquet of the king” (Brenton, modernized).
- i (13:32) Literally “mouth.”
- j (13:34) So the Hebrew; the meaning is uncertain. The Septuagint adds “by the way of Horonaim” (Brenton, “by the way of Oronen,” modernized) and a report to the king.
- k (13:37) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads “Ammihur.” The Septuagint adds “to the land of Chamaachad” (Brenton).
- l (13:39) The Hebrew is uncertain, literally “and David the king was spent to go out to Absalom.” 4QSam-a reportedly reads “the spirit of the king.” The Septuagint reads “King David ceased to go out after Absalom” (Brenton).

Chapter 14

1 Now Joab the son of Zeruiah perceived that the king’s heart went
out to Absalom.[a] 2 Joab sent someone to Tekoa[b] to bring a wise woman
from that town, and he said to her, “Please act like a mourner: dress
in mourning clothes, do not anoint yourself with oil, and be like a
woman who has been grieving over the dead for a long time. 3 Then
go to the king and speak these words to him.” And Joab told her what
to say.
4 When the woman of Tekoa spoke[c] to the king, she fell on her face
to the ground and did obeisance and said, “Save, O king!” 5 And the
king said to her, “What troubles you?” She answered, “Truly I am a
widow; my husband is dead. 6 And your handmaid had two sons, and
they quarreled together in the field. There was no one to part them,
and the one struck the other and killed him. 7 Now the whole clan
has risen up against your servant. They say, ‘Surrender the one who
struck down his brother, so that we may execute him for the life of the
brother he killed.’ That would destroy the heir as well. They would
put out the one ember I have left, and leave my husband without
name or descendant on the earth.”
8 Then the king said to the woman, “Go to your house, and I will give
orders concerning you.” 9 The woman of Tekoa said to the king, “Let
the guilt be on me, my lord the king, and on my father’s house; the
king and his throne are blameless.” 10 “Bring me anyone who speaks
against you,” the king said, “and he will never touch you again.” 11
Then she said, “Please let the king remember Yahweh your God, that

the avenger of blood may destroy no more, lest they destroy my son." He said, "As Yahweh lives, not one hair of your son shall fall to the ground."
12 Then the woman said, "Let your handmaid, I pray, speak a word to my lord the king." He said, "Speak." 13 And the woman said, "Why then have you devised such a thing against the people of God? For in speaking this word the king is as one who is guilty, in that the king does not bring home again his banished one. 14 For we must surely die, and are as water spilled on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again. But God does not take away a life; he devises means so that the banished one is not cast out from him. 15 The reason I have come to say this to my lord the king is that the people have frightened me. So your servant thought, 'Let me speak to the king; perhaps the king will grant his servant's request. 16 For the king will listen, to rescue his handmaid out of the grasp of the man who seeks to cut off both me and my son together from God's inheritance.' 17 Then your handmaid said, 'Let the word of my lord the king be for rest,' for as a messenger[d] of God, so is my lord the king to discern good and evil. And may Yahweh your God be with you!"
18 The king answered the woman, "Please do not conceal from me anything I ask you." "Let my lord the king speak," the woman said. 19 The king asked, "Is Joab's hand behind all this?" The woman replied, "As you live, my lord the king, no one can turn right or left from anything my lord the king says. It was your servant Joab who instructed me, and he told me everything to say to your servant. 20 To change the face of the matter your servant Joab has done this thing. But my lord is wise, according to the wisdom of a messenger of God, to know all things that are in the earth."
21 The king then said to Joab, "Very well, I will do this. Go and bring the young man Absalom back." 22 Joab fell with his face to the ground, bowed low, and blessed the king. "Today your servant knows that I have found favor with you, my lord the king," said Joab, "because the king has granted his servant's request." 23 So Joab arose and went to Geshur and brought Absalom to Jerusalem. 24 The king said, "Let

him turn to his own house; but my face he shall not see." So Absalom turned to his own house and did not see the king's face.
25 Now in all Israel there was none to be so much praised as Absalom for his beauty. From the sole of his foot to the crown of his head there was no blemish in him. 26 And when he polled his head (it was at every year's end that he polled it, because it weighed heavily on him; therefore he polled it), he weighed the hair of his head, about five pounds[e] by the king's weight. 27 There were born to Absalom three sons and one daughter, whose name was Tamar. She was a woman fair to look upon.[f]
28 Absalom lived in Jerusalem for two full years without once seeing the king's face. 29 Then Absalom sent for Joab, to send him to the king, but he would not come to him. And he sent again a second time, but he would not come. 30 Therefore he said to his servants, "See, Joab's field is next to mine, and he has barley there. Go and set it on fire." So Absalom's servants set the field on fire.[g] 31 Then Joab arose and came to Absalom at his house and said to him, "Why have your servants set my field on fire?" 32 Absalom told Joab, "I sent word to you, 'Come here, so that I can send you to the king to ask, "Why did I come back from Geshur? I would be better off still there."' Now let me see the king's face; and if there is any fault in me, let him have me killed." 33 So Joab went to the king and told him. And he called for Absalom. He came to the king and bowed himself on his face to the ground before the king, and the king kissed Absalom.

Notes

- a (14:1) Or "was against Absalom." The Hebrew can be read either way.
- b (14:2) Tekoa was a town about 6 miles (10 kilometers) south of Bethlehem, later the home of the prophet Amos.
- c (14:4) So many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and other versions (reported). The traditional Hebrew text reads "said."
- d (14:17) Or "angel." Likewise in verse 20.
- e (14:26) Hebrew "200 shekels," about 5 pounds (2.3 kilograms). The Septuagint likewise reads "two hundred shekels according to the royal shekel" (Brenton).
- f (14:27) The Septuagint adds, "and she becomes the wife of Rehoboam son of Solomon, and she bears to him Abijah" (Brenton, modernized). Compare 1 Kings 15:2, where Abijah's mother is called Maacah daughter of Abishalom.

- g (14:30) The Septuagint, and 4QSam-a reportedly, add that Joab's servants came to him with torn clothes and told him that Absalom's servants had set the field on fire (Brenton, paraphrased).

Chapter 15

1 After this it came about that Absalom prepared for himself a chariot
and horses, and fifty men to run before him. 2 Absalom would get up
early and stand beside the road leading to the city gate. Whenever
any man with a lawsuit was on his way to the king for a decision,
Absalom would call to him and ask, "What town are you from?" and
when he answered, "Your servant is from one of the tribes of Israel,"
3 then Absalom would tell him, "Look, your matters are sound and
just, but there is none from the king to give you a hearing." 4 Absalom
would say moreover, "O that I were made judge in the land! Then
every man who had a dispute or a cause might come to me, and I
would do him justice." 5 And whenever a man came near to do him
obeisance, he would stretch out his hand and seize him and kiss him.
6 In this manner Absalom did to all Israel who came to the king for
judgment. So Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel.
7 At the end of forty years[a] Absalom said to the king, "Let me go, I pray,
and pay my vow, which I have vowed to Yahweh, in Hebron. 8 While
I was living at Geshur in Aram, your servant made a vow: 'If Yahweh
truly brings me back to Jerusalem, I will worship Yahweh.'"[b] 9 The king
said to him, "Go in peace." So he arose and went to Hebron. 10 Absalom
sent secret messengers to all the tribes of Israel with this instruction:
"As soon as you hear the sound of the trumpet, say, 'Absalom has
become king in Hebron!'" 11 Now with Absalom went two hundred
men out of Jerusalem, men who had been called, and they went in
their simplicity and knew nothing at all. 12 And while he was offering
the sacrifices, Absalom sent for Ahithophel[c] the Gilonite, David's
counselor, from his city, from Giloh. So the plot became mighty, for
the people with Absalom grew ever more in number.
13 A messenger came to David, saying, "The hearts of the men of Israel
have gone after Absalom." 14 David told all his servants who were
with him in Jerusalem, "Come, let us flee, or we will not escape from
Absalom. Hurry and leave, in case he catches up with us quickly,

brings disaster down on us, and puts the city to the sword." 15 The king's servants said to the king, "Look, your servants are ready to do whatever my lord the king shall choose." 16 So the king went out, and all his household after him. And the king left ten concubines to keep the house. 17 And the king went out, and all the people after him, and they halted at the Far House.[d] 18 All his servants marched past at his side, together with all the Cherethites, all the Pelethites, and all the Gittites, six hundred men who had followed him from Gath, and they marched past the king.[e]

19 Then the king said to Ittai[f] the Gittite, "Why do you also go with us? Go back and stay with the king, for you are a foreigner and also an exile from your own place. 20 Yesterday was your coming, and today shall I make you go up and down with us, when I myself go wherever I can go? Return, and take back your brothers with you. Steadfast love and faithfulness be with you."[g] 21 But Ittai answered the king, "As Yahweh lives, and as my lord the king lives, wherever my lord the king may be, whether in death or in life, your servant will be there too." 22 David said to Ittai, "Go on and cross over." So Ittai of Gath went across, with all his men and all the children who were with him. 23 And the whole country was weeping with a great voice while all the people crossed over. And the king went over the brook Kidron,[h] and all the people passed on toward the way of the wilderness.

24 And look, Zadok also came, and all the Levites with him, carrying the ark of the covenant of God. And they set down the ark of God, and Abiathar went up,[i] until all the people had finished passing out of the city. 25 Then the king said to Zadok, "Carry back the ark of God into the city. If I find favor in the eyes of Yahweh, he will cause me to return and will show me it and the place where it dwells. 26 But if he says thus, 'I have no delight in you,' here I am; let him do to me as seems good to him." 27 The king said also to Zadok the priest, "Are you a seer?[j] Return in peace to the city, you and your two sons with you, Ahimaaz your son and Jonathan son of Abiathar. 28 See, I will wait at the fords[k] of the wilderness until word comes from you to inform me." 29 Zadok therefore and Abiathar returned the ark of God to Jerusalem, and there they stayed.

30 But David went up by the ascent of the Mount of Olives, weeping
as he went up, with his head covered, and he went barefoot. And all
the people who were with him covered every man his head, and they
went up, weeping as they went. 31 David was told, "Ahithophel is one
of the conspirators with Absalom." So David prayed, "Yahweh, please
turn Ahithophel's advice into foolishness."
32 When David came to the summit, where God was worshiped, look,
Hushai[l] the Archite came to meet him with his coat torn and earth
upon his head. 33 David said to him, "If you pass on with me, you
will be a burden to me. 34 But if you return to the city and say to
Absalom, 'Your servant I will be, O king; I was your father's servant
formerly, and now I am yours,' then you shall bring to nothing for me
the advice of Ahithophel. 35 And are there not with you Zadok and
Abiathar the priests? So it shall be that every word you hear out of the
king's house, you shall report it to Zadok and Abiathar the priests. 36
Look, they have there with them their two sons, Ahimaaz of Zadok
and Jonathan of Abiathar; and by their hand you shall send me every
word you hear." 37 So Hushai, David's friend, came into the city, just
as Absalom was coming into Jerusalem.

Notes

- a (15:7) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint (Brenton, "after forty years"). Some Septuagint manuscripts, the Syriac, and Josephus reportedly read "four years," which fits the context better (scholarly review).
- b (15:8) Some Septuagint manuscripts reportedly add "in Hebron."
- c (15:12) Ahithophel means "brother of folly" (uncertain), perhaps a scribal alteration. Giloh was a town in the hill country of Judah. The Septuagint reads "the Theconite … from Gola" (Brenton).
- d (15:17) Hebrew Beth-merhak, perhaps the last house of the city.
- e (15:18) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult. The Septuagint has a longer text (Brenton).
- f (15:19) Ittai means "with me" (uncertain).
- g (15:20) So the Septuagint (reported). The Hebrew reads "take back your brothers with you, steadfast love and faithfulness."
- h (15:23) Kidron means "dark" or "turbid," the valley east of Jerusalem.
- i (15:24) Or "offered sacrifices." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (15:27) The Hebrew is uncertain; perhaps "Do you see?" The Septuagint reads "Behold, you shall return" (Brenton, modernized).
- k (15:28) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads "the plains."

• l (15:32) Hushai means “quick” (uncertain).

Chapter 16

1 When David had gone a little past the summit, there was Ziba,
Mephibosheth’s servant, waiting to meet him with a pair of saddled
donkeys carrying two hundred loaves of bread, a hundred raisin
cakes, a hundred bunches of summer fruit,[a] and a skin of wine. 2 The
king said to Ziba, “What do you mean by these?” Ziba said, “The don-
keys are for the king’s household to ride on, the bread and summer
fruit for the young men to eat, and the wine for any who grow faint
in the wilderness.” 3 The king asked, “Where is your master’s son?”
Ziba answered the king, “He is staying in Jerusalem, because he said,
‘Today the house of Israel will give back to me my father’s kingdom.’”
4 Then the king said to Ziba, “Look, everything of Mephibosheth’s is
yours.” And Ziba said, “I bow myself; may I find grace in your sight,
my lord the king.”
5 As King David approached Bahurim,[b] a man from the family of Saul’s
house came out from there, named Shimei[c] son of Gera. He cursed
continually as he came out. 6 And he threw stones at David and at all
the servants of King David, while all the people and all the mighty
men were on his right hand and on his left. 7 And thus said Shimei as
he cursed: “Go out, go out, man of bloodshed, base fellow![d] 8 Yahweh
has paid you back for all the bloodshed in the house of Saul, whose
throne you took, and Yahweh has handed the kingdom over to your
son Absalom. Look at you, ruined by your own wrongdoing, because
you are a man of blood!”
9 Then Abishai the son of Zeruiah said to the king, “Why should this
dead dog curse my lord the king? Let me go over, I pray, and take off
his head.” 10 But the king said, “What have I to do with you, you sons
of Zeruiah? If he is cursing because[e] Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse
David,’ who then shall say, ‘Why have you done so?’” 11 David said to
Abishai and all his servants, “My own son, who came from my body,
is trying to kill me; how much more this Benjamite! Leave him alone
and let him curse, for Yahweh has told him to. 12 It may be that Yahweh
will look on my affliction,[f] and that Yahweh will repay me with good

for his cursing this day." 13 So David and his men went along the road,
and Shimei walked along the side of the hill alongside him, cursing
as he walked, and he hurled stones over against him and threw dust.
14 The king and all the people with him arrived exhausted,[g] and there
he rested.
15 Now Absalom and all the people, the men of Israel, came to
Jerusalem, and Ahithophel with him. 16 When Hushai the Archite,
David's friend, came to Absalom, Hushai said to Absalom, "Long live
the king! Long live the king!" 17 Absalom said to Hushai, "Is this the
kindness you show your companion? Why did you not go with your
companion?" 18 Hushai said to Absalom, "No, but whom Yahweh and
this people and all the men of Israel have chosen, his will I be, and
with him I will remain. 19 And again, whom should I serve? Should it
not be his son? As I have served in your father's presence, so will I
be in your presence."
20 Then Absalom said to Ahithophel, "Give your counsel. What shall
we do?" 21 Ahithophel said to Absalom, "Go in to your father's concu-
bines, whom he has left to keep the house. All Israel will then hear
that you have become a stench to your father, and the hands of all
your supporters will grow strong." 22 They spread for Absalom the tent
upon the housetop, and Absalom went in unto his father's concubines
before the eyes of all Israel. 23 In those days the advice Ahithophel
gave was regarded as if a man had consulted the word of God. That
was how highly all of Ahithophel's advice was valued by both David
and Absalom.

Notes

- a (16:1) Probably cakes of summer fruit such as figs. The Septuagint reads "a hundred cakes of dates" (Brenton).
- b (16:5) Bahurim means "young men," a village east of Jerusalem near the Mount of Olives.
- c (16:5) Shimei means "heard" (short for "Yahweh has heard"). Gera means "grain" (uncertain).
- d (16:7) Hebrew "man of Belial."
- e (16:10) So the traditional reading (qere). The written text reads "If he curses, and if."

- f (16:12) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "look on my affliction") and other ancient versions. The written Hebrew text reads "on my iniquity"; the traditional reading (qere) reads "on my eye," perhaps "my tears."
- g (16:14) The Hebrew reads "arrived weary" without naming a place; perhaps a place name, ʿAyephim, has dropped out (compare 17:22, "the Jordan").

Chapter 17

1 Moreover, Ahithophel said to Absalom, "Let me now choose twelve
thousand men, and I will arise and pursue after David this night. 2 I
will come upon him while he is weary and his hands are slack, and
I will make him tremble, and all the people who are with him will
flee. And I will strike the king alone. 3 And I will bring back all the
people to you. The man whom you seek is as the return of all;[a] so all
the people shall be at peace." 4 And the saying pleased Absalom and
all the elders of Israel.
5 Then Absalom said, "Call now Hushai the Archite also, and let us
hear likewise what is in his mouth." 6 When Hushai came to Absalom,
Absalom spoke to him, saying, "Thus has Ahithophel spoken. Shall
we do according to his word? If not, you speak." 7 Then Hushai said
to Absalom, "The counsel that Ahithophel has given this time is not
good." 8 Hushai added, "You know that your father and his men are
warriors, and they are in a fierce mood, like a bear in the wild robbed
of her cubs. Your father is also an experienced fighter, and he will
not spend the night with the troops. 9 Look, he is hidden now in one
of the pits or in some other place. And it will come to pass, when
some of them fall at the first, that whoever hears it will say, 'There
has been a slaughter among the people who follow Absalom.' 10 Then
even the valiant man, whose heart is as the heart of a lion, will utterly
melt. For all Israel knows that your father is a mighty man, and those
who are with him are valiant men. 11 Therefore I counsel that all Israel
be gathered to you, from Dan even to Beersheba, as the sand that
is by the sea for multitude, and that you go to battle in your own
person.[b] 12 So shall we come upon him in some place where he shall
be found, and we will light upon him as the dew falls on the ground.
And of him and of all the men who are with him there shall not be left
even one. 13 And if he gathers himself into a town, then all Israel will

carry cords to that town, and we will haul it down into the ravine, until not even a pebble is found there." 14 Absalom and all the men of Israel said, "The counsel of Hushai the Archite is better than the counsel of Ahithophel." For Yahweh had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, to the intent that Yahweh might bring evil upon Absalom.

15 Then Hushai said to Zadok and to Abiathar the priests, "Thus and thus did Ahithophel counsel Absalom and the elders of Israel, and thus and thus have I counseled. 16 Now therefore send quickly and tell David, saying, 'Do not lodge this night at the fords of the wilderness, but by all means pass over, lest the king be swallowed up, and all the people who are with him.'" 17 Jonathan and Ahimaaz were staying beside En-rogel.[c] A servant girl used to go and bring them word, and they would go and tell King David, for they dared not be seen coming into the city. 18 But a lad saw them and told Absalom. So the two of them went away quickly and came to the house of a man in Bahurim, who had a well in his courtyard, and they went down into it. 19 The woman took a covering, spread it over the mouth of the well, and scattered grain over it, so that nothing was noticed. 20 When Absalom's servants reached the woman at the house, they asked, "Where are Ahimaaz and Jonathan?" She said to them, "They went across the brook."[d] They searched and found no one, so they returned to Jerusalem.

21 After they had left, the two climbed out of the well and went to inform King David. "Get up and cross the river quickly," they told him, "for Ahithophel has advised this against you." 22 Then David arose, and all the people who were with him, and they crossed the Jordan. By the morning light not one of them was lacking who had not crossed the Jordan.

23 When Ahithophel saw that his counsel was not followed, he saddled his donkey and arose and went home to his city. He set his house in order and hanged himself, and he died and was buried in the tomb of his father.

24 David arrived at Mahanaim, and Absalom crossed the Jordan with all the men of Israel. 25 Absalom set Amasa[e] over the army in place of

Joab. Now Amasa was the son of a man named Ithra the Israelite,[f] who had gone in to Abigal the daughter of Nahash, sister of Zeruiah, Joab's mother. 26 And Israel and Absalom encamped in the land of Gilead.
27 When David came to Mahanaim, Shobi the son of Nahash of Rabbah of the sons of Ammon, and Machir the son of Ammiel of Lo-debar, and Barzillai[g] the Gileadite of Rogelim, 28 brought couches, bowls, and pottery vessels, also wheat and barley, meal and roasted grain, beans and lentils and roasted seeds,[h] 29 honey, curds, sheep, and cheese from cows, for David and his people to eat, for they said, "The people are hungry, tired, and thirsty out in the wilderness."

Notes

- a (17:3) The Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "as a bride returns to her husband: only you seek the life of one man" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (17:11) Hebrew "your face going into battle." Some ancient versions reportedly read "in their midst."
- c (17:17) En-rogel means "spring of the fuller" (uncertain), just south of Jerusalem.
- d (17:20) The meaning of the Hebrew word mikhal is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "gone a little way beyond the water" (Brenton).
- e (17:25) Amasa means "burden" (uncertain).
- f (17:25) So the Hebrew. First Chronicles 2:17 reads "Jether the Ishmaelite"; the Septuagint reads "Jether of Jezreel" (Brenton). Abigal is a form of Abigail.
- g (17:27) Shobi perhaps means "captor" (uncertain). Barzillai means "man of iron." Rogelim means "fullers."
- h (17:28) The Hebrew repeats "parched grain"; the Septuagint lacks the repetition (reported).

Chapter 18

1 Then David mustered the people who were with him and set over them captains of thousands and captains of hundreds. 2 And David sent out the people, a third under the hand of Joab, a third under the hand of Abishai the son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother, and a third under the hand of Ittai the Gittite. And the king said to the people, "I will surely go out with you myself also." 3 But the men said, "You must not go out. If we run away, nobody will worry about us, and if half of us are killed, nobody will worry either. But you are worth ten thousand of us.[a] So it is better that you send help to us from the city." 4 "I will do whatever seems best to you," the king told them. So the king stood

beside the gate while all the troops marched out in units of hundreds and thousands. 5 And the king commanded Joab and Abishai and Ittai, saying, "Deal gently for my sake with the young man, with Absalom." And all the people heard when the king gave all the captains charge concerning Absalom.

6 So the people went out into the field against Israel, and the battle was in the forest of Ephraim.[b] 7 The people of Israel were beaten there before the servants of David, and there was a great slaughter there that day, twenty thousand men. 8 For the battle there was spread over the face of all the country, and the forest devoured more people that day than the sword devoured.

9 Absalom chanced upon the servants of David. Absalom was riding on his mule, and the mule passed beneath the tangled boughs of a great oak, and his head was caught fast in the oak, and he was hung up[c] between the heavens and the earth, and the mule beneath him passed on. 10 And a certain man saw it and told Joab, "Look, I saw Absalom hanging in an oak." 11 Joab said to the man who told him, "And look, you saw him! Why then did you not strike him down there to the ground? It would have been on me to give you ten pieces of silver[d] and a belt." 12 But the man replied to Joab, "Even if a thousand pieces of silver[e] were weighed into my hands, I would not raise my hand against the king's son. We heard the king command you, Abishai, and Ittai, 'Protect[f] the young man Absalom for me.' 13 Else, had I wrought treachery against his life[g]—and no matter is hid from the king—you yourself would have stood off from me." 14 Then Joab said, "I may not linger thus with you." And he took three darts[h] in his hand and thrust them into the heart of Absalom while he was yet alive in the midst of the oak. 15 And ten young men who carried Joab's armor surrounded Absalom and struck him and killed him.

16 Then Joab blew the horn, and the people returned from pursuing after Israel, for Joab held back the people. 17 They took Absalom and cast him into the great pit in the forest and raised over him a very great heap of stones. And all Israel fled, each man to his tent. 18 Now Absalom in his lifetime had taken and set up for himself the pillar which is in the King's Valley, for he said, "I have no son to keep my

name in remembrance."[i] And he called the pillar after his own name, and it is called Absalom's Monument to this day.
19 Then Ahimaaz the son of Zadok said, "Let me now run and carry the king tidings, how Yahweh has delivered him from the hand of his enemies." 20 Joab said to him, "You shall not be the bearer of tidings this day; you shall bear tidings another day. But this day you shall bear no tidings, because the king's son is dead." 21 Then Joab said to the Cushite,[j] "Go, tell the king what you have seen." The Cushite bowed himself to Joab and ran. 22 Ahimaaz son of Zadok again said to Joab, "Whatever happens, please let me run after the Cushite too." Joab asked, "Why run, my son? You will get no reward for this news." 23 "Whatever happens," he said, "I want to run." "Run, then," Joab told him. So Ahimaaz ran by way of the plain[k] and passed the Cushite.
24 Now David was sitting between the two gates. The watchman went up to the roof over the gate by the wall, and he lifted up his eyes and looked, and there was a man running alone. 25 The watchman called out and told the king. The king said, "If he is alone, he has news to report." The runner kept coming closer. 26 Then the watchman spotted another man running. He shouted to the gatekeeper, "Look, a man running alone again!" "That one is bringing news too," said the king. 27 The watchman said, "I think the running of the foremost is like the running of Ahimaaz the son of Zadok." And the king said, "He is a good man and comes with good tidings." 28 Then Ahimaaz called out and said to the king, "All is well!"[l] And he bowed himself before the king with his face to the earth and said, "Blessed be Yahweh your God, who has delivered up the men who lifted up their hand against my lord the king!" 29 The king asked, "Is the young man Absalom safe?" Ahimaaz answered, "When Joab was sending off the king's servant, and your servant as well, I saw a huge uproar, but I did not know what it was about." 30 The king said, "Turn aside and stand here." So he turned aside and stood still. 31 And look, the Cushite came, and the Cushite said, "Let my lord the king receive tidings! For Yahweh has judged for you today against the hand of all those rising against you." 32 The king said to the Cushite, "Is it well with the young man Absalom?" The Cushite answered, "May the enemies of my lord the

king, and all who rise up against you to do you harm, be as that young man is."

33 The king was shaken. He went up to the room over the gateway and wept, and as he went he said, "My son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! If only I had died instead of you, Absalom, my son, my son!"[m]

Notes

- a (18:3) So two Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint (Brenton, "you are as ten thousand of us"), and the Vulgate (reported). The traditional Hebrew text reads "for now there are ten thousand like us."
- b (18:6) The forest of Ephraim was east of the Jordan, in Gilead, despite its name.
- c (18:9) So the Septuagint and other ancient versions (reported). The Hebrew reads "he was set."
- d (18:11) Hebrew "ten of silver," that is, ten shekels, about 4 ounces (115 grams).
- e (18:12) Hebrew "a thousand of silver," that is, a thousand shekels, about 25 pounds (11.5 kilograms). The Septuagint reads "a thousand shekels of silver" (Brenton).
- f (18:12) So some Hebrew manuscripts and ancient versions (reported), reading "for me." The traditional text reads "whoever you are."
- g (18:13) So the written Hebrew text (ketiv); the traditional reading (qere) is "my life." Marked for scholarly review.
- h (18:14) Hebrew "three sticks" or "three rods"; perhaps spears or javelins.
- i (18:18) Compare 14:27, which says Absalom had three sons; perhaps they died young.
- j (18:21) That is, a man from Cush, the region south of Egypt (Nubia).
- k (18:23) That is, the plain of the Jordan Valley.
- l (18:28) Hebrew "Peace!"
- m (18:33) In Hebrew this verse is 19:1, and 19:1–43 in English is 19:2–44 in Hebrew. The Septuagint follows the Hebrew numbering (Brenton).

Chapter 19

1 It was told Joab, "Look, the king weeps and mourns for Absalom."[a] 2 So the victory that day was turned into mourning for all the people, for the people heard it said that day, "The king grieves for his son." 3 And the people crept into the city on that day, the way a people creeps in that is put to shame by fleeing in the fight. 4 But the king covered his face, and the king cried with a loud voice, "O my son Absalom, O Absalom, my son, my son!"

5 Joab went into the house to the king and said, “Today you have
humiliated all your servants, who today saved your life, and the lives
of your sons and daughters, your wives, and your concubines, 6 in
that you love your haters and hate your lovers. For you have made
known today that princes and servants count for nothing with you.
For this day I know that had Absalom lived and we all died this day,
that would have been pleasing in your sight. 7 Now then, rise, go forth
and speak kindly to your servants. For by Yahweh I swear, unless you
go forth, not one man will stay the night with you; and that will be
a greater evil to you than every evil that has come upon you from
your youth until now.” 8 Then the king arose and sat in the gate. And
they told all the people, saying, “Look, the king is sitting in the gate.”
And all the people came before the king. Now Israel had fled, every
man to his tent. 9 Throughout all the tribes of Israel the people were
quarreling and saying, “The king delivered us from our enemies’ grip
and rescued us from Philistine power, yet now he has had to flee the
land because of Absalom. 10 But Absalom, whom we anointed over
us, has died in the battle. So now, why are you silent about returning
the king?”
11 King David sent word to the priests Zadok and Abiathar: “Tell the
elders of Judah, ‘Why should you be the last to bring the king back
to his palace, when what all Israel is saying has already reached the
king at his house?[b] 12 You are my brothers; you are my bone and my
flesh. Why then should you be the last to bring back the king?’ 13 And
say to Amasa, ‘Are you not my bone and my flesh? God do so to me
and more also, if you shall not be commander of the army before me
continually in the place of Joab.’” 14 So he swayed the heart of all the
men of Judah as one man, and they sent word to the king, “Return,
you and all your servants.” 15 So the king returned and came to the
Jordan. And Judah came to Gilgal to go to meet the king, to bring the
king over the Jordan.
16 Shimei the Benjamite, son of Gera, from Bahurim, hurried and went
down with the men of Judah to meet King David. 17 And a thousand
men of Benjamin were with him, and Ziba the servant of Saul’s house,
and his fifteen sons and his twenty servants with him; and they

rushed down to the Jordan before the king. 18 They crossed the ford[c] to carry the king's household over and to do whatever he wished. As the king was about to cross the Jordan, Shimei son of Gera threw himself down before him 19 and he said to the king, "Let not my lord reckon iniquity to me, nor remember how your servant did perversely on the day my lord the king went out of Jerusalem, that the king should take it to his heart. 20 For your servant knows that I have sinned. Therefore, look, I have come today, the first of all the house of Joseph, to go down to meet my lord the king." 21 But Abishai the son of Zeruiah answered and said, "Shall not Shimei be put to death for this, because he cursed the anointed of Yahweh?" 22 But David said, "What have I to do with you, you sons of Zeruiah, that you should this day become an adversary[d] to me? Shall any man be put to death in Israel today? Am I not sure that today I am king over Israel?" 23 The king told Shimei, "You will not die," and gave him his oath.

24 Then Mephibosheth the son of Saul came down to meet the king. He had not dressed his feet nor trimmed his beard nor washed his clothes, from the day the king departed until the day he came again in peace. 25 And when he came from Jerusalem[e] to meet the king, the king asked him, "For what reason did you not go along with me, Mephibosheth?" 26 He answered, "My lord the king, my servant deceived me. Your servant had planned to say, 'I will have a donkey saddled so that I can ride and go with the king,' because your servant is lame. 27 And he has slandered your servant to my lord the king. But my lord the king is as an angel of God. Do therefore what is good in your eyes. 28 For all my father's house were nothing but men of death before my lord the king, yet you placed your servant with those eating at your table. What right more have I, that I should still cry to the king?" 29 The king said to him, "Why say more about your affairs? I have decided: you and Ziba will divide the land." 30 And Mephibosheth said to the king, "Indeed, let him take it all, since my lord the king has come safely to his own house."

31 Now Barzillai the Gileadite had come down from Rogelim, and he crossed to the Jordan with the king, to send him on his way across the Jordan. 32 Barzillai was very old, eighty years of age. He had supplied

the king with food during his stay at Mahanaim, for he was a man of great wealth. 33 And the king said to Barzillai, "Cross over with me, and I will provide for you with me in Jerusalem." 34 But Barzillai said to the king, "How many are the days of the years of my life, that I should go up with the king to Jerusalem? 35 Today I am eighty years old. Can I distinguish good from bad? Can your servant savor what he eats or drinks? Can I still listen to the voices of male and female singers? So why should your servant add to my lord the king's load? 36 Your servant would go just a little way over the Jordan with the king. And why should the king repay me with such a reward? 37 Let your servant go back, please, so that I can die in my hometown near the grave of my father and mother. But your servant Chimham[f] is here. Let him cross over with my lord the king, and do for him whatever you think good." 38 And the king answered, "Chimham shall go over with me, and I will do to him whatever is good in your eyes; and all that you choose to ask of me, that will I do for you." 39 Then all the people went over the Jordan, and the king went over. And the king kissed Barzillai and blessed him, and he returned to his own place.
40 When the king crossed over to Gilgal, Chimham crossed along with him. All the troops of Judah and half the troops of Israel brought the king across. 41 And look, all the men of Israel came to the king and said to the king, "Why have our brothers the men of Judah stolen you away and brought the king and his household over the Jordan, and all David's men with him?" 42 The men of Judah answered the men of Israel, "It is because the king is a near relative of ours. Why does this make you angry? Have we eaten at the king's expense? Have we taken any gift for ourselves?" 43 And the men of Israel answered the men of Judah, "Ten parts in the king are ours, and in David too we have a greater claim than you.[g] Why then have you made light of us? Was not our word the first to bring back our king?" But the words of the men of Judah were fiercer than the words of the men of Israel.

Notes

- a (19:1) English 19:1–43 is Hebrew 19:2–44; English 18:33 is Hebrew 19:1. The Septuagint follows the Hebrew numbering.

- b (19:11) The Hebrew places the clause “when the word of all Israel has come to the king” at the end of the verse; the Septuagint has it in the same place (Brenton).
- c (19:18) Hebrew uncertain; perhaps “And the ferry crossed over.”
- d (19:22) Or “a satan,” that is, an accuser or opponent.
- e (19:25) Or “came to Jerusalem.”
- f (19:37) Chimham perhaps means “longing” (uncertain). He is apparently Barzillai’s son (compare 1 Kings 2:7).
- g (19:43) The Septuagint reads “we are older than you” (Brenton); some scholars reportedly prefer “we are the firstborn rather than you.”

Chapter 20

1 A scoundrel[a] named Sheba[b] son of Bichri, a Benjamite, was there by
chance. He blew a horn and proclaimed, “We have no part in David,
no inheritance in Jesse’s son. Everyone to your tents, Israel!” 2 So all
the men of Israel deserted David and followed Sheba son of Bichri,
but the men of Judah stayed with their king all the way from the
Jordan to Jerusalem.
3 And David came to his house at Jerusalem. And the king took the
ten women, his concubines, whom he had left to keep the house, and
placed them in a house of ward and fed them, yet he went not in unto
them. So they were shut up until the day of their death, living as in
widowhood.
4 Then the king said to Amasa, “Summon me the men of Judah
within three days, and you yourself be present here.” 5 Amasa went
to summon Judah, but he took longer than the time he had been
given. 6 And David said to Abishai, “Now Sheba the son of Bichri
will do us more harm than Absalom. Take your lord’s servants and
pursue after him, lest he find for himself fortified cities and escape
out of our sight.”[c] 7 Joab’s men, the Cherethites, the Pelethites, and
all the warriors marched out after Abishai. They left Jerusalem to
pursue Sheba son of Bichri. 8 When they were at the great stone that
is in Gibeon, Amasa came to meet them. Now Joab was girded in
his soldier’s garment, and over it was a belt with a sword fastened
upon his loins in its sheath; and as he went forward, it fell out. 9 And
Joab said to Amasa, “Is it well with you, my brother?” And Joab took
Amasa by the beard with his right hand to kiss him. 10 Amasa did not
notice the sword in Joab’s hand, and Joab stabbed him in the stomach,

spilling his intestines on the ground. He did not need to strike him again, and Amasa died. Then Joab and his brother Abishai went on in pursuit of Sheba son of Bichri. 11 And one of Joab's young men stood over him and said, "He who delights in Joab, and he who is David's, let him go after Joab." 12 And Amasa lay wallowing in his blood in the middle of the highway. And when the man saw that all the people stood still, he carried Amasa out of the highway into the field and threw a garment over him, since he saw that everyone who came by him stood still. 13 When he was removed from the highway, every man went on after Joab to pursue Sheba the son of Bichri.

14 And Sheba passed through all the tribes of Israel to Abel of Beth-maacah,[d] and all the Bichrites[e] gathered together and followed him in also. 15 They came and besieged him in Abel of Beth-maacah, building a siege ramp against the city that rose against its outer wall. Meanwhile all the troops with Joab were hammering the wall to make it fall. 16 Then a wise woman cried from the city, "Hear, hear! Say, I pray you, to Joab, 'Come near here, that I may speak with you.'" 17 He came near to her, and the woman said, "Are you Joab?" He answered, "I am." Then she said to him, "Hear the words of your maidservant." And he said, "I am listening." 18 Then she spoke, saying, "They used to speak in former times, saying, 'Let them but ask counsel at Abel,' and so they ended the matter.[f] 19 I am of those who are peaceable and faithful in Israel. You seek to destroy a city and a mother in Israel. Why will you swallow up the inheritance of Yahweh?" 20 Joab answered and said, "Far be it, far be it from me, that I should swallow up or destroy! 21 That is not the case. A man from the hill country of Ephraim, named Sheba son of Bichri, has raised his hand against the king, against David. Give him up alone, and I will leave the city." "His head will be tossed to you over the wall," the woman told Joab. 22 Then the woman went to all the people in her wisdom. And they cut off the head of Sheba the son of Bichri and threw it out to Joab. So he blew the horn, and they dispersed from the city, every man to his tents. And Joab returned to Jerusalem to the king.

23 Now Joab was over all the army of Israel, and Benaiah the son of Jehoiada was over the Cherethites and over the Pelethites, 24 and

Adoram[g] was in charge of the labor gangs, and Jehoshaphat son
of Ahilud was recorder, 25 and Sheva was secretary, and Zadok and
Abiathar were priests, 26 and also Ira the Jairite[h] was a priest to David.

Notes

- a (20:1) Hebrew "a man of belial."
- b (20:1) Sheba perhaps means "seven" or "oath" (uncertain). Bichri perhaps means "youthful" or "firstborn" (uncertain).
- c (20:6) Hebrew uncertain; literally "and snatch away our eye." The Septuagint reads "so he will blind our eyes" (Brenton, modernized).
- d (20:14) Abel of Beth-maacah means "meadow of the house of Maacah," in the far north.
- e (20:14) So the Hebrew; some ancient versions reportedly read "Berites" or "all the choice men."
- f (20:18) The Septuagint reads a longer saying about asking in Abel and in Dan whether the faithful in Israel had failed (Brenton); some scholars reportedly think "and in Dan" is original.
- g (20:24) Adoram is a shortened form of Adoniram (1 Kings 4:6), the reading of the Septuagint (Brenton).
- h (20:26) The Septuagint reads "Iras the son of Iarin" (Brenton). Jairite refers to the clan of Jair, a Manassite (Numbers 32:41).

Chapter 21

1 Now there was a famine in the days of David for three years, year
following year. And David sought the face of Yahweh. And Yahweh
said, "It is on account of Saul and his house of blood, because he put
the Gibeonites to death." 2 The king summoned the Gibeonites and
spoke to them. (The Gibeonites were not Israelites but a remnant of
the Amorites; the Israelites had sworn an oath to them,[a] but in his
zeal for Israel and Judah Saul had tried to wipe them out.) 3 And David
said to the Gibeonites, "What shall I do for you? And with what shall
I make atonement, that you may bless the inheritance of Yahweh?" 4
The Gibeonites answered him, "Between us and Saul or his house it
is not a question of silver or gold, and we have no right to put anyone
in Israel to death." "Then what do you say?" he asked. "I will do it for
you." 5 They said to the king, "The man who consumed us and who
planned against us, that we should be destroyed from remaining in
any of the borders of Israel, 6 let seven men of his sons be given to us,

and we will hang them up[b] to Yahweh at Gibeah of Saul, the chosen of Yahweh."[c] And the king said, "I will give them."

7 But the king spared Mephibosheth, the son of Jonathan the son of Saul, because of the oath of Yahweh that was between them, between David and Jonathan the son of Saul. 8 The king took Rizpah daughter of Aiah's two sons by Saul, Armoni and Mephibosheth, along with the five sons that Merab[d] daughter of Saul bore to Adriel son of Barzillai the Meholathite. 9 And he gave them into the hand of the Gibeonites, and they hanged them on the mountain before Yahweh, and the seven of them fell together. They were put to death in the days of harvest, in the first days, at the start of barley harvest.[e]

10 Then Rizpah the daughter of Aiah took sackcloth and spread it for herself upon the rock, from the beginning of harvest until water poured upon them from the heavens. And she let neither the birds of the air settle on them by day nor the beasts of the field by night. 11 When it was told David what Rizpah the daughter of Aiah, the concubine of Saul, had done, 12 David went and collected the bones of Saul and his son Jonathan from the citizens of Jabesh-gilead, who had taken them secretly from the public square of Beth-shan, where the Philistines had hung them the day they defeated Saul on Gilboa. 13 And he brought up from there the bones of Saul and the bones of Jonathan his son, and they gathered the bones of those who were hanged. 14 And they buried the bones of Saul and Jonathan his son in the land of Benjamin in Zela,[f] in the tomb of Kish his father. And they did all that the king commanded. And after that God was moved by entreaty for the land.

15 The Philistines had war again with Israel, and David went down, and his servants with him, and they fought against the Philistines. And David grew weary. 16 And Ishbi-benob,[g] who was one of the descendants of the giants,[h] whose spearhead weighed about 7½ pounds[i] of bronze, and who was girded with something new,[j] thought to kill David. 17 But Abishai son of Zeruiah helped him, and he struck down the Philistine and slew him. Then the men of David took an oath to him, saying, "Never again shall you go forth with us into battle, lest you put out the lamp of Israel."

18 And it came to pass after this that there was once more war with the
Philistines at Gob. At that time Sibbecai the Hushathite slew Saph,
who was among the offspring of the giants. 19 And there was again a
battle with the Philistines at Gob, and Elhanan son of Jaare-oregim,
the Bethlehemite, slew Goliath of Gath,[k] and the wood of his spear
was like a weaver's beam. 20 And there was again a battle at Gath,
where there was a man of great stature, who had six fingers on each
hand and six toes on each foot, twenty-four in number; and he also
was born to the giant. 21 And when he taunted Israel, Jonathan the
son of Shimei,[l] David's brother, struck him down. 22 These four were
born to the giant in Gath, and they fell by the hand of David and by
the hand of his servants.

Notes

- a (21:2) See Joshua 9:3–27.
- b (21:6) The exact form of execution is uncertain; perhaps "impale" or "expose." So also verses 9 and 13.
- c (21:6) So the Hebrew. Some scholars, following a reported reading, emend to "on the mountain of Yahweh" (compare verse 9). The Septuagint reads "in Gibeon of Saul, as chosen out for the Lord" (Brenton, modernized).
- d (21:8) So two Hebrew manuscripts and some Septuagint manuscripts (reported); compare 1 Samuel 18:19. Most Hebrew manuscripts and Brenton's Septuagint read "Michal." Armoni perhaps means "of the palace" (uncertain).
- e (21:9) Barley harvest fell in April–May.
- f (21:14) Zela perhaps means "rib" or "side" (uncertain).
- g (21:16) So the traditional reading (qere). Ishbi-benob perhaps means "his dwelling is in Nob" (uncertain).
- h (21:16) Hebrew "the Rapha" or "the Raphah," the ancestor of a race of giants (Deuteronomy 2:11); so also verses 18, 20, and 22.
- i (21:16) Hebrew "three hundred shekels," about 7½ pounds (3.4 kilograms). The Septuagint also reads "three hundred shekels of brass" (Brenton).
- j (21:16) Hebrew "girded with a new [thing]"; the noun is missing. The Septuagint reads "girded with a club" (Brenton).
- k (21:19) First Chronicles 20:5 says that Elhanan son of Jair killed Lahmi, brother of Goliath the Gittite. Compare 1 Samuel 17, where David kills Goliath. "Oregim" means "weavers" and may have been copied from the end of the verse. Marked for scholarly review.
- l (21:21) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads "Shimei"; elsewhere he is called Shimeah (13:3) or Shammah (1 Samuel 16:9).

Chapter 22

1 And David spoke to Yahweh the words of this song on the day when
Yahweh delivered him from the hand of all his enemies and from the
hand of Saul.[a]
2 He said: "Yahweh is my crag and my stronghold and my deliverer, 3
my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield and the horn[b] of
my salvation, my high retreat and my place of flight, my savior; from
violence you save me. 4 I call upon Yahweh, who is to be praised, and
from my enemies I am saved.
5 "For the breakers of death encircled me; the torrents of worthless-
ness[c] terrified me; 6 the cords of Sheol[d] surrounded me; the snares
of death came to meet me. 7 When I was hemmed in, I cried out to
Yahweh; unto my God I cried. Out of his temple my voice was heard
by him; my cry for help reached his ears.
8 "Then the earth heaved and rocked; the bases of the heavens quiv-
ered and tottered, for his anger burned. 9 Smoke rose from his nostrils,
and consuming fire from his mouth; burning coals blazed out of him.
10 He bowed the heavens and came down, and thick darkness was
under his feet. 11 He rode upon a cherub and flew; he was seen[e] upon
the wings of the wind. 12 He made darkness around him his shelters,
a gathering of waters, thick clouds of the skies. 13 From the brightness
before him coals of fire were kindled. 14 Yahweh thundered from the
heavens, and the Most High gave forth his voice. 15 He sent out arrows
and scattered them, lightning, and routed them. 16 Then the channels
of the sea appeared; the foundations of the world were laid bare at
the rebuke of Yahweh, at the blast of the breath of his nostrils.
17 "He sent from on high; he took me; he drew me out of many waters.
18 He delivered me from my strong enemy, from those who hated me,
for they were too strong for me. 19 They came upon me in the day of
my calamity, but Yahweh was my support. 20 He led me forth into a
wide space; he set me free, for he took pleasure in me.
21 "Yahweh dealt with me according to my righteousness; according
to the cleanness of my hands he repaid me. 22 For I have kept the ways
of Yahweh, and have not done wickedly against my God. 23 For all his
rulings were in front of me, and his decrees I did not put away from

me. 24 I was blameless in his sight, and I guarded myself from wrongdoing. 25 And Yahweh has repaid me according to my righteousness,
according to my cleanness before his eyes.
26 "To the faithful one you are faithful; to the mighty man of integrity
you deal with integrity; 27 to the cleansed one you deal cleanly, but
to the twisted one you deal shrewdly. 28 And the afflicted people you
save, but your eyes are upon the haughty, to bring them low. 29 For
you are my lamp, O Yahweh, and Yahweh lights up my darkness. 30
For with you I rush upon a raiding band; with my God I spring over
a rampart. 31 As for God, his way is perfect; Yahweh's word is proven
true; he is a shield for all who shelter in him.
32 "For who is God, besides Yahweh? And who is a rock, besides our
God? 33 This God is my strong fortress,[f] and he sets the blameless
free in his way.[g] 34 He makes my feet like the feet of does, and sets
me upon my high places. 35 He teaches my hands to make war, and
my arms bend a bronze bow. 36 You have given me the shield of your
salvation, and your answering[h] has made me great. 37 You widened my
stride beneath me, and my ankles did not slip. 38 I chased my foes and
wiped them out; I turned not back till I had made an end of them. 39 I
consumed them; I shattered them, so that they did not rise; they fell
beneath my feet. 40 You dressed me with strength for the battle; you
made my attackers sink beneath me. 41 You gave me the necks of my
foes; my haters—I put an end to them. 42 They looked, but there was
none to save; they cried to Yahweh, but he did not answer them. 43 I
beat them fine as the dust of the earth; I crushed them and stamped
them like the mire of the streets.
44 "You delivered me from the strivings of my people;[i] you kept me as
the head of the nations; a people whom I had not known served me. 45
Sons of a foreign land came cringing to me; at the hearing of the ear
they hearkened to me. 46 Sons of a foreign land faded away and came
quaking[j] from their strongholds.
47 "Yahweh lives! Blessed be my rock; exalted be God, the rock who
saves me, 48 the God who gives me vengeance and brings down
peoples under me, 49 who brings me out from my enemies. You lift me
up above those who rise against me; you deliver me from the man of

violence. 50 For this I will praise you, O Yahweh, among the nations,
and sing praises to your name. 51 He gives great victories[k] to his king
and shows faithful love to his anointed, to David and his descendants
forever."

Notes

- a (22:1) This song closely parallels Psalm 18, with many small differences in wording.
- b (22:3) "Horn" is a figure for strength.
- c (22:5) Hebrew "belial."
- d (22:6) Sheol is the Hebrew name for the realm of the dead.
- e (22:11) So the Hebrew; Psalm 18:10 and some Hebrew manuscripts read "he soared" (reported). The Septuagint reads "was seen" (Brenton).
- f (22:33) So the Hebrew; Psalm 18:32 reads "who girds me with strength," and the Septuagint here reads "who strengthens me with might" (Brenton).
- g (22:33) Hebrew uncertain; perhaps "and has made my way blameless" (compare Psalm 18:32), so the Septuagint (Brenton).
- h (22:36) Or "your humility," "your condescension"; Psalm 18:35 reads "your gentleness." The Septuagint reads "your propitious dealing" (Brenton).
- i (22:44) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Psalm 18:43 read "the people" (reported).
- j (22:46) So Psalm 18:45; the Hebrew here reads "girded themselves" (uncertain).
- k (22:51) So the traditional reading (qere), as in Psalm 18:50 "great salvation"; the written text reads "He is a tower." Marked for scholarly review.

Chapter 23

1 These are the last words of David: "David son of Jesse declares, the
man raised up on high declares, the anointed of Jacob's God, Israel's
sweet singer:[a] 2 "The Spirit of Yahweh speaks by me; his word is upon
my tongue. 3 The God of Israel spoke; the Rock of Israel said to me:
'One who rules people with justice, who rules in the fear of God, 4
is like the light of morning when the sun rises, a morning without
clouds, when from brightness after rain the tender grass springs out
of the earth.'
5 "Is my house not like this with God? He has made an everlasting
covenant with me, arranged in every detail and made secure. Will he
not make all my salvation and every desire grow?[b] 6 But worthless
men[c] are all like thorns thrust away, for they cannot be taken with the

hand; 7 and the man who touches them must be armed with iron and
a spear's wood, and they are utterly burned with fire in their place."[d]
8 These are the names of the mighty men whom David had: Josheb-
basshebeth a Tahchemonite,[e] chief of the three.[f] He was Adino the
Eznite; he wielded his spear[g] against eight hundred whom he slew at
one time.
9 After him came Eleazar son of Dodo, son of Ahohi, among the three
warriors with David when they challenged the Philistines assembled
there for battle while the Israelites pulled back. 10 He rose up and
struck the Philistines until his hand grew tired and stuck to his sword.
Yahweh brought about a great victory that day, and the troops came
back after him only to plunder the dead.
11 And next to him was Shammah son of Agee, a Hararite. When the
Philistines had assembled at Lehi,[h] there was a portion of a field full
of lentils there, and the people fled before the Philistines. 12 But he
took his stand in the midst of the plot and defended it and struck the
Philistines. And Yahweh wrought a great salvation.
13 And three of the thirty chief men went down and came at harvest
time to David at the cave of Adullam, while a troop of Philistines
was encamped in the valley of Rephaim. 14 David was then in the
stronghold, and the garrison of the Philistines was then at Bethlehem.
15 David was longing for water and said, "If only someone would bring
me a drink from the well by the gate at Bethlehem!" 16 So the three
warriors broke through the Philistine camp, drew water from the well
by the gate at Bethlehem, and carried it back to David. But he refused
to drink any of it and poured it out to Yahweh 17 and said, "Far be it
from me, O Yahweh, that I should do this. Is it not the blood of the
men who went with their lives in their hands?" So he was not willing
to drink it. These things the three mighty men did.
18 Now Abishai, the brother of Joab, the son of Zeruiah, was chief of
the three.[i] And he wielded his spear against three hundred and slew
them, and he had a name among the three. 19 Was he not the most
honored of the three?[j] And he became their commander, but he did
not attain to the three.

20 And Benaiah the son of Jehoiada was the son of a valiant man[k]
of Kabzeel, great in deeds. He struck down the two sons of Ariel[l] of
Moab. He also went down and struck a lion in the midst of a pit on a
day of snow. 21 He also killed an Egyptian, an impressive man.[m] The
Egyptian held a spear, but Benaiah went down against him with a
club, wrenched the spear from his hand, and killed him with his own
spear. 22 These things Benaiah the son of Jehoiada did, and he had
a name among the three mighty men. 23 Among the thirty he was
honored, yet to the three he did not come. And David appointed him
over his bodyguard.[n]
24 Asahel the brother of Joab was one of the thirty; Elhanan the son of
Dodo of Bethlehem, 25 Shammah of Harod, Elika of Harod, 26 Helez the
Paltite, Ira the son of Ikkesh of Tekoa, 27 Abiezer of Anathoth, Mebun-
nai the Hushathite, 28 Zalmon the Ahohite, Maharai of Netophah, 29
Heleb son of Baanah from Netophah, and Ittai son of Ribai from
Gibeah of the Benjamites, 30 Benaiah of Pirathon, Hiddai of the brooks
of Gaash, 31 Abi-albon the Arbathite, Azmaveth of Bahurim, 32 Eliahba
of Shaalbon, the sons of Jashen, Jonathan,[o] 33 Shammah the Hararite,
Ahiam the son of Sharar the Hararite, 34 Eliphelet son of Ahasbai, the
son of the Maacathite; Eliam son of Ahithophel the Gilonite, 35 Hezro
of Carmel, Paarai the Arbite, 36 Igal the son of Nathan of Zobah, Bani
the Gadite, 37 Zelek the Ammonite, and Naharai the Beerothite, the
armor-bearer of Joab son of Zeruiah, 38 Ira the Ithrite, and also Gareb
the Ithrite, 39 and Uriah the Hittite—thirty-seven in all.[p]

Notes

- a (23:1) Or “the favorite of the songs of Israel,” or “the delight of the Strong One of Israel” (uncertain). The Septuagint reads “and beautiful are the psalms of Israel” (Brenton, modernized).
- b (23:5) Or as a statement: “For he will cause to sprout all my salvation and all my desire.”
- c (23:6) Hebrew “belial.”
- d (23:7) Hebrew “in the sitting” (uncertain); perhaps “on the spot.”
- e (23:8) Josheb-basshebeth means “one who sits in the seat” (uncertain). First Chronicles 11:11 reads “Jashobeam, a Hachmonite”; the Septuagint reads “Jebosthe the Chananite” (Brenton), which may reflect Ishbosheth or Ishbaal (compare 2:8). Marked for scholarly review.

- f (23:8) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads “the captain” or “of the third ones.” Some Septuagint manuscripts reportedly read “of the three.”
- g (23:8) So 1 Chronicles 11:11 and the Septuagint (Brenton, “he drew his sword against eight hundred”), in part. The Hebrew phrase “He was Adino the Eznite” is uncertain; Chronicles has instead “he wielded his spear,” and reads “three hundred.” Marked for scholarly review.
- h (23:11) Or “at Lehi” (compare Judges 15:9); possibly “in a troop.” Lehi means “jawbone.”
- i (23:18) So the Hebrew; two Hebrew manuscripts and the Syriac reportedly read “of the thirty.”
- j (23:19) Or “He was more honored than the three” (uncertain); compare 1 Chronicles 11:21.
- k (23:20) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text reads “a living man.”
- l (23:20) Ariel perhaps means “lion of God” (uncertain); the Hebrew reads only “the two Ariel of Moab,” perhaps “two champions of Moab.” The Septuagint reads “the two sons of Ariel of Moab” (Brenton).
- m (23:21) Hebrew “a man of appearance”; 1 Chronicles 11:23 reads “a man of great stature, five cubits tall” (about 7 feet 6 inches, 2.3 meters).
- n (23:23) Hebrew “his bodyguard,” literally “those who listen”; perhaps a privy council.
- o (23:32) Hebrew uncertain; 1 Chronicles 11:34 reads “the sons of Hashem the Gizonite, Jonathan son of Shagee.”
- p (23:39) The list as it stands names fewer than thirty-seven; the total probably includes the leaders named in verses 8–23 and Joab (uncertain).

Chapter 24

1 Once more the anger of Yahweh was kindled against Israel, and he
incited David against them, saying, “Go, number Israel and Judah.”[a] 2
So the king said to Joab, the commander of the army, who was with
him, “Go now to and fro through all the tribes of Israel, from Dan to
Beersheba, and muster the people, that I may know the number of
the people.” 3 But Joab said to the king, “Now may Yahweh your God
increase the people a hundredfold, however many they may be, and
may the eyes of my lord the king behold it! But my lord the king,
why does he take pleasure in this matter?” 4 Nevertheless the word
of the king was stronger than Joab and the army’s commanders. So
Joab went out, with the army’s commanders, from before the king to
count the people of Israel. 5 They crossed the Jordan and encamped at
Aroer, on the right side of the city that is in the middle of the valley of

Gad, and on toward Jazer. 6 Then they came to Gilead and to the land
of Tahtim-hodshi,[b] and they came to Dan-jaan and around to Sidon, 7
They came to the fortress of Tyre and all the cities of the Hivites and
Canaanites, and they finished at the Negeb of Judah at Beersheba. 8 So
when they had gone through all the land, they came to Jerusalem at
the end of nine months and twenty days. 9 And Joab handed over the
total of the census of the people to the king: Israel had eight hundred
thousand men of valor drawing the sword, and the men of Judah were
five hundred thousand men.[c]
10 But David's heart struck him after he had numbered the people.
And David said to Yahweh, "I have sinned greatly in what I have
done. But now, O Yahweh, take away, I pray, the iniquity of your
servant, for I have acted very foolishly." 11 And when David arose in
the morning, the word of Yahweh came to the prophet Gad, David's
seer, saying, 12 "Go and tell David, 'This is what Yahweh says: I am
offering you three options. Pick one of them, and that is what I will
do to you.'" 13 So Gad came to David and told him and said to him,
"Shall seven[d] years of famine come to you in your land? Or will you
flee three months before your foes while they pursue you? Or shall
there be three days' pestilence in your land? Now consider and see
what answer I shall return to him who sent me." 14 David answered
Gad, "I am very distressed. Let us fall into Yahweh's hand, for his
compassion is great, but do not let me fall into the hand of man."
15 So Yahweh sent a plague upon Israel from morning to the time
appointed.[e] And from Dan even to Beersheba seventy thousand men
of the people died. 16 And when the angel stretched out his hand
toward Jerusalem to destroy it, Yahweh relented from the evil and
said to the destroying angel among the people, "Enough! Now let
your hand drop." And the angel of Yahweh was by the threshing floor
of Araunah[f] the Jebusite. 17 Then David spoke to Yahweh when he
saw the angel who was striking the people, and said, "Look, it is I
who have sinned, and I who have done wrong. But these sheep, what
have they done? Let your hand turn, I beg you, upon me and upon
the house of my father."

18 And Gad came that day to David and said to him, “Go up, raise
an altar to Yahweh on the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite.”
19 So David went up according to the word of Gad, as Yahweh had
commanded. 20 Araunah looked and saw the king and his servants
approaching. He went out and bowed down before the king with his
face to the ground. 21 And Araunah said, “Why has my lord the king
come to his servant?” David said, “To buy the threshing floor from
you, to build an altar to Yahweh, that the plague may be held back
from the people.” 22 Araunah said to David, “May my lord the king
take it and offer whatever he sees fit. Here are the oxen for the burnt
offering, and the threshing sledges and the oxen’s yokes for fuel. 23
The whole of it, O king, Araunah hands over to the king.”[g] Araunah
said also to the king, “May Yahweh your God take pleasure in you.” 24
But the king said to Araunah, “No, but I will surely buy it from you
for a price. I will not offer burnt offerings to Yahweh my God that
cost me nothing.” So David bought the threshing floor and the oxen
for about 20 ounces of silver.[h] 25 David built an altar to Yahweh there
and presented burnt offerings and peace offerings.[i] Then Yahweh
answered the prayer for the land, and the plague on Israel was halted.

Notes

- a (24:1) Compare 1 Chronicles 21:1, where Satan incites David.
- b (24:6) Hebrew uncertain; Tahtim-hodshi may mean “lowlands of Hodshi.” The Septuagint reads “the land of Thabason, which is Adasai” (Brenton); some scholars emend to “Kadesh in the land of the Hittites” (reported).
- c (24:9) First Chronicles 21:5 gives 1,100,000 for Israel and 470,000 for Judah. The Septuagint here agrees with the Hebrew (Brenton).
- d (24:13) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint (Brenton) and 1 Chronicles 21:12 read “three.”
- e (24:15) Or “until the time of the assembly” (uncertain). The Septuagint reads “from morning till noon” and adds that it was the days of wheat harvest (Brenton).
- f (24:16) So the traditional reading (qere); the written Hebrew text spells the name in several ways in this chapter (reported). First Chronicles 21:15 calls him Ornan; the Septuagint reads “Orna” (Brenton). The name may be Hurrian, perhaps a title meaning “lord” (uncertain).
- g (24:23) Or “All this, O king, does Araunah give to the king.” Some interpreters reportedly read “Araunah the king,” suggesting a former Jebusite ruler.

- h (24:24) Hebrew “fifty shekels,” about 20 ounces (575 grams). First Chronicles 21:25 reads “six hundred shekels of gold” (about 15 pounds, 6.9 kilograms) for the whole site.
- i (24:25) The Septuagint adds “and Solomon made an addition to the altar afterwards, for it was little at first” (Brenton, modernized).

1 Kings

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Now King David was old and well along in years. They would cover
him with clothes, yet he could not keep warm. 2 His servants told him,
"Let a young woman, a virgin, be found for my lord the king to wait
on him and look after him. She can lie in your arms, and my lord the
king will stay warm." 3 So they looked for a lovely girl in every part
of the land of Israel, and they found Abishag[a] the Shunammite[b] and
brought her to the king. 4 The young woman was very beautiful. She
took care of the king and served him, but the king did not know her.
5 Then Adonijah[c] son of Haggith[d] began to exalt himself, saying, "I am
the one who will be king." He got chariots and horsemen ready for
himself, with fifty men running ahead of him. 6 His father had never
once rebuked him by saying, "Why have you done this?" He was also
very handsome, and he was born next after Absalom.[e] 7 He conferred
with Joab the son of Zeruiah and with Abiathar[f] the priest, and they
followed Adonijah and helped him. 8 But Zadok[g] the priest, Benaiah[h]
the son of Jehoiada, Nathan[i] the prophet, Shimei, Rei,[j] and David's
mighty men were not with Adonijah.
9 Adonijah slaughtered sheep, cattle, and fattened calves at the Stone
of Zoheleth,[k] next to En-rogel.[l] He invited all his brothers, the king's
sons, and all the men of Judah who served the king, 10 Nathan the
prophet, though, and Benaiah and the mighty men and his brother
Solomon[m] he left uninvited.
11 Nathan then spoke to Bathsheba[n] the mother of Solomon. "Have
you not heard," he said, "that Haggith's son Adonijah reigns now, and
David our lord knows nothing of it? 12 So come now, let me counsel
you, so that you can rescue your own life and your son Solomon's
life. 13 Go in at once to King David and say to him, 'My lord the king,
did you not promise your servant, "Your son Solomon is to reign after

me and sit on my throne"? Then why is Adonijah king?' 14 While you
are still speaking there with the king, I will come in after you and
confirm your words."
15 So Bathsheba went in to the king in his room. The king was very old,
and Abishag the Shunammite was attending the king. 16 Bathsheba
bowed down and paid homage to the king, and the king said, "What
do you wish?" 17 She said to him, "My lord, you yourself swore to your
servant by Yahweh your God, 'Surely Solomon your son will reign
after me, and he will sit on my throne.' 18 But now, look, Adonijah
has become king, and you, my lord the king, do not know it. 19 He
has offered oxen and fatlings and sheep in great numbers, and has
called all the king's sons, with Abiathar the priest and Joab the army's
commander, but your servant Solomon he did not call. 20 And as for
you, my lord the king, the eyes of all Israel are on you, for you to
tell them who will sit on the throne of my lord the king after him. 21
Otherwise, when my lord the king lies down with his fathers, I and
my son Solomon will be counted as offenders."
22 And look, she was still talking with the king when Nathan the
prophet arrived. 23 They told the king, "Here is Nathan the prophet."
He came before the king and bowed down to the king with his face to
the ground. 24 Nathan said, "My lord the king, did you say, 'Adonijah
will reign after me, and he will sit on my throne'? 25 Today he went
down and sacrificed a great number of oxen, fattened calves, and
sheep. He invited Abiathar the priest, the commanders of the army,
and all the king's sons, and even now they sit eating and drinking
in his presence, shouting, 'Long live King Adonijah!' 26 But me, your
servant, and Zadok the priest, and Benaiah the son of Jehoiada, and
Solomon your servant, he has not invited. 27 Has this thing been done
by my lord the king without your letting your servants[o] know who
should sit on the throne of my lord the king after him?"
28 Then King David answered, "Call Bathsheba to me." She came into
the king's presence and stood before the king. 29 The king swore,
saying, "As Yahweh lives, who has redeemed my life out of every
distress, 30 just as I swore to you by Yahweh the God of Israel, saying,
'Surely Solomon your son will reign after me, and he will sit on my

throne in my place,' so I will do this very day." 31 Then Bathsheba
bowed low, her face to the earth, and did obeisance to the king. "May
my lord King David live forever!" she said.
32 King David said, "Call to me Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet,
and Benaiah the son of Jehoiada." They came before the king. 33 The
king said to them, "Take with you the servants of your lord, have
Solomon my son ride on my own mule, and bring him down to
Gihon.[p] 34 There let Zadok the priest and Nathan the prophet anoint
him king over Israel. Then blow the horn and say, 'Long live King
Solomon!' 35 Then you shall come up after him, and he shall come and
sit on my throne, and he shall reign in my place. I have appointed him
to be ruler over Israel and over Judah." 36 Benaiah the son of Jehoiada
answered the king, "Amen! May Yahweh, the God of my lord the king,
say so too. 37 As Yahweh has been with my lord the king, so may he be
with Solomon, and may he make his throne greater than the throne
of my lord King David."
38 So Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet, Benaiah the son of
Jehoiada, and the Cherethites and the Pelethites[q] went down and had
Solomon ride on King David's mule, and they brought him to Gihon.
39 Zadok the priest took the horn of oil from the tent and anointed
Solomon. Then they blew the horn, and all the people said, "Long live
King Solomon!" 40 Then all the people came up behind him, piping
on flutes and rejoicing greatly, until the ground split[r] at the sound
of them.
41 Adonijah and all his guests heard it just as they had finished eating.
Joab heard the trumpet sound and said, "What is this noise of the
city in uproar?" 42 While he was still speaking, Jonathan the son of
Abiathar the priest came. Adonijah said, "Come in, for you are a
worthy man and bring good news." 43 Jonathan answered Adonijah,
"No! Our lord King David has made Solomon king. 44 The king has
sent with him Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet, Benaiah the son
of Jehoiada, and the Cherethites and the Pelethites, and they had him
ride on the king's mule. 45 Zadok the priest and Nathan the prophet
have anointed him king at Gihon. They went up from there rejoicing,
and now the whole city is in an uproar; that is the sound you

heard. 46 Solomon is even sitting now on the throne of the kingdom.
47 Moreover, the king's servants came to bless our lord King David,
saying, 'May your God make the name of Solomon more famous than
your name, and make his throne greater than your throne.' And the
king bowed himself on the bed. 48 The king also said this: 'Blessed be
Yahweh, the God of Israel, who has granted today one to sit on my
throne,[s] while my own eyes see it.'"
49 Then all the guests of Adonijah trembled. They got up, and each
one went his own way. 50 And Adonijah, afraid because of Solomon,
arose and went and caught hold of the altar's horns. 51 Word came to
Solomon: "Adonijah fears King Solomon. See, he has caught hold of
the altar's horns, and he says, 'Let King Solomon swear to me today
that he will not kill his servant by the sword.'" 52 Solomon said, "If he
will act as a worthy man, not a hair of his shall fall to the earth; but if
wickedness is found in him, he shall die." 53 So King Solomon sent, and
they brought him down from the altar. He came and bowed down to
King Solomon, and Solomon said to him, "Go to your house."

Notes

- a (1:3) Abishag may mean "my father wanders" or "my father is a wanderer"; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (1:3) That is, from Shunem, a town in the territory of Issachar (Joshua 19:18). The name Shunem perhaps means "resting place"; the meaning is uncertain.
- c (1:5) Adonijah means "Yahweh is my Lord."
- d (1:5) Haggith means "festive" or "born on a feast day."
- e (1:6) Hebrew "and she bore him after Absalom," referring to his mother Haggith. Adonijah was apparently the oldest of David's surviving sons (2 Samuel 3:2–4).
- f (1:7) Abiathar means "the father is abundant" or "father of abundance."
- g (1:8) Zadok means "righteous."
- h (1:8) Benaiah means "Yahweh has built."
- i (1:8) Nathan means "he has given."
- j (1:8) The Hebrew names Shimei and Rei are otherwise unknown here. Some ancient witnesses read "Shimei and his friends" (reading reʿaw instead of reʿi); the identification is uncertain.
- k (1:9) Zoheleth may mean "serpent" or "crawling one," so "the Serpent Stone"; the meaning is uncertain.
- l (1:9) En-rogel means "spring of the fuller" (or "spring of the foot," perhaps from washing clothes by treading them). It lay just south of Jerusalem, where the Kidron and Hinnom valleys meet.

- m (1:10) Solomon is related to the Hebrew shalom, “peace,” and may mean “his peace” or “his replacement.”
- n (1:11) Bathsheba means “daughter of an oath” or “daughter of abundance.”
- o (1:27) This follows the written Hebrew text (Ketiv). The traditional reading (Qere) has “your servant.”
- p (1:33) Gihon means “gushing,” a name for the spring in the Kidron Valley that supplied Jerusalem.
- q (1:38) The Cherethites and the Pelethites were the king’s bodyguard, probably mercenaries of Cretan and Philistine origin.
- r (1:40) Or “burst.” The Septuagint reads “they danced in choirs” for “playing on pipes,” and “the earth quaked.”
- s (1:48) The Septuagint adds “from my offspring.”

Chapter 2

1 As David’s days to die drew near, he charged Solomon his son: 2 “I am
going the way of all the earth. Be strong, and show yourself a man.
3 Keep what Yahweh your God has charged you to keep: walk in his
ways and keep his statutes and commandments, his judgments and
testimonies, as they are written in the Law of Moses, so that you may
succeed in all you do and wherever you turn, 4 and so that Yahweh
will fulfill the promise he made about me: ‘If your descendants watch
how they live and walk faithfully before me with all their heart and
all their soul, a man of your line will never be missing from Israel’s
throne.’
5 “You know too what Joab son of Zeruiah did to me, and what he did
to the two army commanders of Israel, Abner son of Ner and Amasa
son of Jether: he murdered them, and in time of peace shed the blood
of war, and put the blood of war on the belt at his waist and on the
sandals on his feet.[a] 6 So deal with him as your wisdom directs, and
do not allow his gray hair to go down to Sheol[b] in peace. 7 But show
kindness to the sons of Barzillai[c] the Gileadite, and let them be among
those who eat at your table, for they came to meet me in this way
when I fled from Absalom your brother. 8 And there is also with you
Shimei[d] the son of Gera, the Benjaminite from Bahurim, who cursed
me with a bitter curse on the day when I went to Mahanaim.[e] But he
came down to meet me at the Jordan, and I swore to him by Yahweh,
saying, ‘I will not put you to death with the sword.’ 9 So now you must

not leave him unpunished. You are a wise man, and you will know what to do with him; bring his gray head down to Sheol with blood."
10 Then David lay down with his fathers and was buried in the city of David. 11 The days that David reigned over Israel were forty years. He reigned seven years in Hebron and thirty-three years in Jerusalem. 12 So Solomon sat on the throne of David his father, and his kingdom was firmly established.
13 Then Adonijah the son of Haggith came to Bathsheba the mother of Solomon. She said, "Do you come peaceably?" He said, "Peaceably."
14 He went on, "I have a word for you." "Say it," she replied. 15 He said, "You know that the kingdom was mine, and all Israel looked to me to reign. But the kingdom has turned about and become my brother's, for it was his from Yahweh. 16 Now I have a single request to ask of you. Do not turn me down." "Say it," she replied. 17 "Please ask King Solomon, since he will not refuse you, to give me Abishag the Shunammite as my wife." 18 "Good," Bathsheba answered. "I will speak for you to the king."
19 Bathsheba went in to King Solomon to speak for Adonijah. The king stood up to meet her and bowed to her, then sat down on his throne. A throne was placed for the king's mother, and she took her seat at his right hand. 20 "There is one small thing I ask of you," she said. "Do not refuse me." The king answered her, "Ask, my mother, for I will not refuse you." 21 She said, "Let Abishag the Shunammite be given to Adonijah your brother as his wife." 22 King Solomon replied to his mother, "Why are you asking for Abishag the Shunammite for Adonijah? Why not ask for the kingdom for him too, since he is my elder brother? Abiathar the priest and Joab son of Zeruiah are on his side!"[f] 23 Then King Solomon swore by Yahweh: "May God deal with me, and worse, if Adonijah has not made this request at the cost of his own life! 24 Now therefore, as Yahweh lives, who has established me and set me on the throne of David my father, and who has made me a house as he promised, Adonijah will be put to death today." 25 So King Solomon sent by the hand of Benaiah son of Jehoiada, who fell upon him, and he died.

26 And to Abiathar the priest the king said, “Go off to Anathoth,[g] to
your own fields, for you are a man worthy of death. I will not kill
you today, though, since you bore the ark of the Lord Yahweh before
David my father, and you suffered in all that my father suffered.” 27
So Solomon expelled Abiathar from being priest to Yahweh, to fulfill
the word of Yahweh that he had spoken concerning the house of Eli
in Shiloh.[h]
28 When the news reached Joab, he fled to Yahweh’s tent and grabbed
the horns of the altar, for Joab had supported Adonijah, though he
had not supported Absalom.[i] 29 King Solomon was told, “Joab has fled
to the tent of Yahweh, and there he is, beside the altar.” Then Solomon
sent Benaiah the son of Jehoiada, saying, “Go, strike him down.”[j] 30
Benaiah went to Yahweh’s tent and told Joab, “The king says, ‘Come
out.’” “No,” he replied, “I will die here.” Benaiah reported to the king
what Joab had answered. 31 The king said to him, “Do as he has said.
Strike him down and bury him, and so take away from me and from
my father’s house the blood that Joab shed without cause. 32 Yahweh
will bring his bloodshed back on his own head, because he struck
down two men more righteous and better than he, and killed them
with the sword without my father David knowing it: Abner the son
of Ner, commander of the army of Israel, and Amasa the son of Jether,
commander of the army of Judah. 33 So their blood will come back
on the head of Joab and on the head of his offspring forever. But for
David and his offspring, his house and his throne, there will be peace
from Yahweh forever.” 34 Benaiah son of Jehoiada went up, struck
Joab down, and killed him. He was buried at his own house in the
wilderness. 35 In his place the king set Benaiah son of Jehoiada over
the army, and Zadok the priest the king set in Abiathar’s place.[k]
36 Then the king sent for Shimei and called him. “Build a house for
yourself in Jerusalem,” he told him, “and stay there. Do not leave it to
go anywhere at all. 37 For on the day you go out and cross the Kidron
Valley,[l] know for certain that you will surely die. Your blood will be
on your own head.” 38 “What you have said is good,” Shimei told the
king. “Your servant will do exactly as my lord the king has said.” And
Shimei remained in Jerusalem for a long time.

39 But at the end of three years two of Shimei's slaves ran away to
Achish the son of Maacah, king of Gath. When Shimei was told, "Your
slaves are in Gath," 40 Shimei got up, saddled his donkey, and went to
Gath to Achish to look for his slaves. Shimei went and brought his
slaves back from Gath. 41 Solomon was told that Shimei had gone from
Jerusalem to Gath and had returned. 42 The king summoned Shimei
and asked him, "Did I not make you swear by Yahweh and warn you
that on the day you leave and go anywhere at all, you would certainly
die? And you told me, 'What I have heard is good; I will obey.' 43
Why then have you not kept the oath of Yahweh and the command
that I gave you?" 44 And the king said to Shimei, "You know all the
wrong, which your own heart is aware of, that you did to my father
David. Now Yahweh is returning your wrong on your own head. 45 But
King Solomon will be blessed, and David's throne will stand secure
before Yahweh forever." 46 The king then commanded Benaiah son of
Jehoiada, who went out and struck Shimei down, and he died. So the
kingdom was firmly in Solomon's hands.[m]

Notes

- a (2:5) The Septuagint reads "and put innocent blood on his belt … and on his sandal." Some ancient witnesses read "my belt" and "my sandals," making the guilt fall on David himself.
- b (2:6) Sheol is the Hebrew name for the realm of the dead.
- c (2:7) Barzillai means "man of iron" (from barzel, "iron").
- d (2:8) Shimei is a shortened form of a name meaning "Yahweh has heard" (or simply "heard").
- e (2:8) Mahanaim means "two camps" (Genesis 32:2).
- f (2:22) Hebrew "and for him and for Abiathar the priest and for Joab the son of Zeruiah." The Septuagint reads "and he has as his companions Abiathar the priest and Joab the son of Zeruiah, the commander-in-chief." The translation follows the general sense.
- g (2:26) Anathoth was a Levitical city in Benjamin, about 3 miles (5 kilometers) northeast of Jerusalem, and later the home of Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:1). The name may recall the goddess Anath.
- h (2:27) See 1 Samuel 2:27–36. Shiloh may mean "place of rest" or "tranquility"; the meaning is uncertain.
- i (2:28) The Septuagint reads "and he had not followed Solomon" for "although he had not sided with Absalom."

- j (2:29) The Septuagint adds "Solomon sent to Joab, saying, 'What has happened to you, that you have fled to the altar?' Joab said, 'Because I was afraid of you, and I fled to Yahweh.'" before the command to Benaiah.
- k (2:35) After this verse the Septuagint adds a long section, usually numbered 2:35a–o. It gathers material about Solomon that appears elsewhere in the Hebrew: his wisdom (compare 4:29–30), his marriage to Pharaoh's daughter (3:1; 9:24), his laborers (5:15), the temple furnishings (ch. 7), his building works and cities (9:15–24), his three yearly offerings (9:25), his officials over the work (5:16; 9:23), and David's charge concerning Shimei (2:8–9). Scholars call these collections the "miscellanies." The Septuagint also adds at the start of verse 35 "and the kingdom was established in Jerusalem," and makes Zadok "high priest."
- l (2:37) The Kidron Valley runs along the east side of Jerusalem, between the city and the Mount of Olives. Kidron may mean "dark" or "murky." Crossing it on the road east toward Bahurim would take Shimei home.
- m (2:46) After this verse the Septuagint adds a second section, usually numbered 2:46a–l. It describes Solomon's wisdom and prosperity, the people "eating and drinking and rejoicing" (compare 4:20), his rule over all the kingdoms, his daily provisions (compare 4:22–23), his building of Tadmor (compare 9:18), a list of his officials (compare 4:2–6), his horses and chariots (compare 4:26), and his rule from the Euphrates to Egypt (compare 4:21, 24).

Chapter 3

1 Solomon formed an alliance by marriage with Pharaoh king of
Egypt. He married Pharaoh's daughter and brought her to the City of
David, until he completed his own palace, Yahweh's house, and the
wall around Jerusalem. 2 Only, the people still sacrificed at the high
places, since up to then no house had been built for Yahweh's name.
3 Solomon loved Yahweh, walking in the statutes of David his father,
except that he sacrificed and burned incense at the high places. 4 The
king went to Gibeon[a] to sacrifice there, for that was the great high
place. A thousand burnt offerings Solomon offered up on that altar.
5 At Gibeon Yahweh appeared to Solomon in a dream by night, and
God said, "Ask what I should give you." 6 Solomon said, "You have
dealt with great faithful love toward your servant my father David,
since he walked before you in truth and righteousness and with an
upright heart toward you; and you have kept this great faithful love
for him and given him a son who sits on his throne, as it is this day. 7
And now, Yahweh my God, you have made your servant king in place
of David my father, though I am only a little child. I do not know how

to go out or come in.[b] 8 And your servant stands among your people
whom you chose, a people so great that they cannot be numbered or
counted for multitude. 9 So grant your servant a heart that listens[c] in
order to govern your people and to distinguish right from wrong. For
who can govern this great people of yours?"
10 It pleased the Lord[d] that Solomon had asked for this. 11 God said
to him, "Because you have asked for this and not for long life for
yourself, nor for riches, nor for your enemies' deaths, but for under-
standing so as to administer justice, 12 look, I have done as you asked.
I have given you a heart so wise and understanding that there has
been no one like you before you, nor will anyone like you arise after
you. 13 I will also give you what you did not ask for, wealth and honor,
so that in your lifetime there will be no king like you. 14 And if you
walk in my ways, keeping my statutes and my commandments, as
David your father walked, then I will lengthen your days." 15 Solomon
woke up and realized it had been a dream. He went to Jerusalem and
stood in front of the ark of the Lord's covenant.[e] There he presented
burnt offerings and peace offerings, and he gave a banquet for all his
servants.
16 Then two women who were prostitutes came to the king and stood
before him. 17 One of the women said, "Please, my lord, this woman
and I dwell in one house, and I bore a child there while she was in
the house. 18 Then three days after my child was born, this woman
had a baby too. We were together, and no stranger was with us in the
house; there were only we two in the house. 19 This woman's son died
in the night, because she lay on him. 20 And she rose at midnight and
took my son from my side while your maidservant slept, and she laid
him in her bosom, and her dead son she laid in my bosom. 21 In the
morning I got up to nurse my son, and found him dead. But when I
looked at him carefully in the light of morning, I saw that he was not
the son I had given birth to." 22 "No," said the other woman, "my son
is the one who is alive; your son is the dead one." "Not so," said the
first, "your son is dead, and mine is alive." And so they argued before
the king.

23 Then the king said, “This one says, ‘This is my son, the living one,
and your son is the dead one,’ and that one says, ‘No, your son is the
dead one, and my son is the living one.’” 24 The king said, “Get me a
sword.” So they brought a sword before the king. 25 The king said, “Cut
the living child in two, and give half to one and half to the other.” 26
Then the woman whose son was alive spoke to the king, because her
heart ached for her son: “Please, my lord, give her the living child;
do not put him to death in any way!” The other said, “Neither of us
will have him. Divide him!” 27 Then the king answered, “Give the first
woman the living child. Do not kill him at all. She is the mother.” 28
When all Israel heard the judgment the king had given, they feared
the king, for they saw that God’s wisdom was in him for doing justice.

Notes

- a (3:4) Gibeon was a city of Benjamin about 6 miles (10 kilometers) northwest of Jerusalem. Its name means “hill” or “height.”
- b (3:7) That is, how to lead, especially in war (compare Numbers 27:17).
- c (3:9) Or “a hearing heart,” that is, an attentive and obedient mind.
- d (3:10) Hebrew Adonai, “Lord,” here rather than Yahweh.
- e (3:15) Hebrew Adonai, “Lord,” here rather than Yahweh.

Chapter 4

1 King Solomon was king over all Israel, 2 and these were the officials
he had: Azariah[a] son of Zadok was the priest; 3 Elihoreph and Ahijah
the sons of Shisha were scribes; and Jehoshaphat[b] son of Ahilud was
recorder; 4 Benaiah son of Jehoiada was over the army; Zadok and
Abiathar were priests; 5 Azariah son of Nathan was over the district
officers; Zabud son of Nathan was priest and the king’s friend;[c] 6
Ahishar was over the household; and Adoniram[d] son of Abda was
over the forced labor.
7 Solomon had twelve district officers over all Israel, who provided
food for the king and his household. Each one had to provide for
one month in the year. 8 These were their names: Ben-hur,[e] in the
hill country of Ephraim; 9 Ben-deker, in Makaz, Shaalbim,[f] Beth-
shemesh,[g] and Elon-beth-hanan; 10 Ben-hesed, in Arubboth (Socoh
and all the land of Hepher belonged to him); 11 Ben-abinadab, all the
heights of Dor[h] (Taphath the daughter of Solomon was his wife);

12 Baana son of Ahilud, Taanach and Megiddo,[i] and all Beth-shean,[j]
which is beside Zarethan below Jezreel,[k] from Beth-shean as far as
Abel-meholah,[l] as far as beyond Jokmeam; 13 Ben-geber, in Ramoth-
gilead[m] (the villages of Jair son of Manasseh, which are in Gilead,
were his, and the region of Argob, which is in Bashan, were his:
sixty great cities with walls and bronze bars); 14 Ahinadab son of Iddo,
in Mahanaim; 15 Ahimaaz, in Naphtali (he too took a daughter of
Solomon, Basemath, as wife); 16 Baana son of Hushai, in Asher and
Bealoth; 17 Jehoshaphat son of Paruah, in Issachar; 18 Shimei son of Ela,
in Benjamin; 19 Geber son of Uri, in the land of Gilead, the country of
Sihon king of the Amorites and of Og king of Bashan. And there was
one officer who was over the land.[n]
20 Judah and Israel were numerous, like the sand that is by the sea for
multitude, eating and drinking and rejoicing. 21 [o]Solomon was ruling
over all the kingdoms from the River[p] to the land of the Philistines
and to the border of Egypt. They brought tribute and served Solomon
all the days of his life.
22 Solomon's provision for one day was about 180 bushels[q] of fine flour
and about 360 bushels of meal, 23 ten fattened oxen, twenty pasture-
fed oxen, and a hundred sheep, besides deer, gazelles, roebucks, and
fattened fowl.[r] 24 He controlled all the land west of the Euphrates, from
Tiphsah[s] to Gaza,[t] together with all its kings, and he had peace with
every neighbor around him. 25 During Solomon's whole reign, Judah
and Israel, from Dan to Beersheba,[u] lived in safety, each man under
his own vine and fig tree. 26 Solomon also had forty thousand[v] stalls of
horses for his chariots, and twelve thousand horsemen. 27 The district
officers supplied food for King Solomon and for everyone who dined
at his table, each in his own month, and saw that nothing was lacking.
28 Barley also and straw for the horses and the swift steeds they
brought to wherever it was needed, every man as he was assigned.
29 God gave Solomon wisdom and very great understanding, and
breadth of mind[w] like the sand on the seashore, 30 Solomon's wisdom
was greater than all the wisdom of the people of the east and than
all Egypt's wisdom. 31 He was wiser than any other man, wiser than
Ethan the Ezrahite and than Heman, Calcol, and Darda, the sons of

Mahol. His reputation spread through all the surrounding nations. [32] He spoke three thousand proverbs, and his songs numbered a thousand and five.[x] [33] He talked about plants, from the cedar of Lebanon to the hyssop growing out of walls. He also taught about animals, birds, reptiles, and fish. [34] People came from all the peoples to hear the wisdom of Solomon, from all the kings of the earth who had heard of his wisdom.

Notes

- a (4:2) Azariah means "Yahweh has helped."
- b (4:3) Jehoshaphat means "Yahweh has judged."
- c (4:5) "The king's friend" was a title for a trusted royal adviser (compare 2 Samuel 15:37).
- d (4:6) Adoniram means "my Lord is exalted." He is called Adoram in 2 Samuel 20:24 and 1 Kings 12:18 (some witnesses there read Adoniram).
- e (4:8) The names in verses 8–13 that begin with Ben- mean "son of" the person named, so Ben-hur is "son of Hur." The officers are identified by their fathers' names.
- f (4:9) Shaalbim means "place of foxes" (or "jackals").
- g (4:9) Beth-shemesh means "house of the sun."
- h (4:11) Hebrew Naphath-dor. Dor was a coastal city south of Mount Carmel.
- i (4:12) Megiddo guarded the main pass through the Carmel ridge into the Valley of Jezreel. The meaning of the name is uncertain.
- j (4:12) Beth-shean means "house of quiet" or "house of security"; the meaning is uncertain.
- k (4:12) Jezreel means "God sows."
- l (4:12) Abel-meholah means "meadow of dancing."
- m (4:13) Ramoth-gilead means "heights of Gilead."
- n (4:19) The Hebrew is uncertain. It may mean that Geber was the only officer over that large region, or it may refer to an officer over the land of Judah, which is not named in the list. The Septuagint reads "and one officer in the land of Judah."
- o (4:21) Hebrew Bibles number verses 21–34 as 5:1–14, and 5:1–18 as 5:15–32. In the Septuagint much of the material in verses 20–21 and 25–26 appears instead in the addition after 2:46 (2:46a–l).
- p (4:21) That is, the Euphrates River.
- q (4:22) Hebrew "thirty cors" and "sixty cors." A cor was a dry measure equal to a homer, about 6 bushels or 220 liters, so about 6,600 liters and 13,200 liters. The size of the cor is not certain.
- r (4:23) The kind of fowl is uncertain. It may be "fattened geese" or "cuckoos."
- s (4:24) Tiphsah, on the Euphrates, means "crossing" or "ford."
- t (4:24) Gaza was the southernmost of the Philistine cities on the coast.

- u (4:25) Dan, in the far north, means “judge”; Beersheba, in the far south, means “well of seven” or “well of the oath” (Genesis 21:31).
- v (4:26) Some Hebrew manuscripts and 2 Chronicles 9:25 read “four thousand.” The Septuagint addition at 2:46i reads “forty thousand mares.”
- w (4:29) Hebrew “breadth of heart.”
- x (4:32) The Septuagint reads “five thousand.”

Chapter 5

1 Hiram[a] king of Tyre[b] sent his servants to Solomon, having heard
that they had anointed him king in his father’s stead; for Hiram had
loved David all his days. 2 Solomon sent word to Hiram, saying, 3 “You
know how my father David was not able to build a house for the
name of Yahweh his God because of the wars that surrounded him on
every side, until Yahweh put his enemies under the soles of his feet.
4 But now Yahweh my God has given me rest on every side. There is
neither adversary nor misfortune. 5 So I intend to build a house for
the name of Yahweh my God, as Yahweh spoke to David my father,
saying, ‘Your son, whom I will set on your throne in your place, will
build the house for my name.’ 6 Now command that cedars be cut for
me in Lebanon. My servants will be with yours, and I will pay your
servants any wage you name. You know that none among us has the
skill to cut timber as the Sidonians do.”
7 When Hiram heard the words of Solomon, he rejoiced greatly and
said, “Blessed be Yahweh today, who has given to David a wise son
over this great people.” 8 Hiram sent to Solomon, saying, “I have
heard the message you sent me. I will do all you desire concerning
timber of cedar and timber of cypress. 9 My servants will haul it down
from Lebanon to the sea, and I will have it made into rafts and sent
by sea to whatever place you name. There I will have them broken
up, and you can take them away. And you will satisfy my wish by
supplying food for my household.” 10 So Hiram gave Solomon all the
cedar timber and cypress timber that he desired, 11 and Solomon gave
Hiram about 120,000 bushels[c] of wheat as food for his household, and
about 1,200 gallons[d] of pressed oil. Solomon gave this to Hiram year
by year. 12 Yahweh gave Solomon wisdom, as he had promised him.

There was peace between Hiram and Solomon, and the two of them made a treaty.

13 King Solomon conscripted forced labor from all Israel, a work force of thirty thousand men. 14 He sent them to Lebanon by turns, ten thousand each month: a month they were in Lebanon, and two months at home. Adoniram was over the levy. 15 Solomon also had seventy thousand burden carriers and eighty thousand stonecutters in the hill country, 16 besides Solomon's chief officers who were over the work, three thousand three hundred,[e] who had charge of the people who did the work. 17 At the king's command they quarried great stones, costly stones, to lay the foundation of the house with dressed stones. 18 So Solomon's builders and Hiram's builders and the Gebalites[f] did the cutting, and they prepared the timber and the stones to build the house.[g]

Notes

- a (5:1) Hiram is a shortened form of Ahiram, "my brother is exalted." Hebrew Bibles number 5:1–18 as 5:15–32.
- b (5:1) Tyre means "rock," describing the island fortress off the coast of Phoenicia.
- c (5:11) Hebrew "twenty thousand cors." A cor was about 6 bushels or 220 liters, so about 4,400,000 liters (4,400 cubic meters). The size of the cor is not certain.
- d (5:11) Hebrew "twenty cors." As a liquid measure a cor equaled ten baths, about 60 gallons or 220 liters, so about 4,400 liters. The Septuagint reads "twenty thousand baths" (compare 2 Chronicles 2:10), about 120,000 gallons or 440,000 liters.
- e (5:16) The Septuagint reads "three thousand six hundred," as does 2 Chronicles 2:18.
- f (5:18) That is, men of Gebal (Byblos), a Phoenician city north of Sidon. Gebal means "border" or "mountain."
- g (5:18) The Septuagint adds "for three years." It places verse 17 at the start of chapter 6, in an addition (6:1a–d) that also says the men of Solomon and of Hiram cut the stones.

Chapter 6

1 In the 480th year[a] after the Israelites came out of Egypt, in the fourth year of Solomon's reign over Israel, in Ziv (April–May),[b] the second month, he began building Yahweh's house. 2 The house that King Solomon built for Yahweh was about 90 feet long, 30 feet wide, and 45 feet high.[c] 3 The porch in front of the main hall[d] of the house extended

about 30 feet[e] across the width of the house, and it was about 15 feet[f] deep in front of the house. 4 For the house he made windows with recessed frames.[g] 5 Against the wall of the house he built a structure all around, against the walls of the house all around both the main hall and the inner sanctuary,[h] and he made side rooms all around. 6 The lowest story was about 7½ feet wide, the middle one about 9 feet wide, and the third about 10½ feet wide.[i] For on the outside of the house he made ledges all around the wall, so that the beams would not be fastened into the walls of the house. 7 When the house was being built, it was built of stone made ready at the quarry, so that neither hammer nor axe nor any iron tool was heard in the house while it was being built. 8 The door to the lowest[j] story was on the right-hand, southern side of the house, and by winding stairs[k] people climbed to the middle level, and from there to the third. 9 So he built the house and finished it, and he roofed the house with beams and rows of planks of cedar. 10 And he built the side structure against all the house, each level about 7½ feet[l] high,and fastened it to the house with timbers of cedar.

11 Then the word of Yahweh came to Solomon:[m] 12 "Concerning this house that you are building: if you walk in my statutes and carry out my judgments and keep all my commandments by walking in them, then I will fulfill with you my word that I spoke to David your father. 13 And I will make my dwelling in the midst of the children of Israel, and I will not abandon Israel my people."

14 So Solomon built the house and finished it. 15 He lined the walls of the house on the inside with boards of cedar. From the floor of the house up to the rafters[n] of the ceiling he covered them on the inside with wood, and he covered the floor of the house with boards of cypress.[o] 16 He built about 30 feet[p] at the rear of the house with boards of cedar from the floor to the rafters. He built this inside as an inner sanctuary, as the Most Holy Place. 17 The house, that is, the main hall in front of the inner sanctuary, was about 60 feet[q] long. 18 The cedar paneling inside the house was carved with gourds and open flowers. Everything was cedar; no stone could be seen.[r] 19 He prepared the inner sanctuary in the middle of the house, within, to set there the ark

of the covenant of Yahweh. 20 The inner sanctuary was about 30 feet
long, 30 feet wide, and 30 feet high,[s] and he overlaid it with pure gold.
He also overlaid the altar with cedar.[t] 21 Solomon covered the house
within with pure gold, and he stretched golden chains across before
the inner sanctuary, and covered it with gold. 22 The whole house he
overlaid with gold, until all the house was finished. Also the whole
altar that belonged to the inner sanctuary he overlaid with gold.
23 In the inner sanctuary he made two cherubim[u] of olive wood,[v] each
about 15 feet[w] high. 24 One wing of the cherub was about 7½ feet long,
and the other wing of the cherub was about 7½ feet long; from the tip
of one wing to the tip of the other was about 15 feet.[x] 25 The second
cherub also measured about 15 feet. Both cherubim had the same
measure and the same shape. 26 The height of one cherub was about
15 feet, and so was that of the other cherub. 27 He placed the cherubim
inside the innermost house. Their wings were stretched out, the wing
of the one reaching to one wall and the wing of the second cherub
reaching to the other wall, while in the middle of the house their
wings met, wing to wing. 28 He overlaid the cherubim with gold.
29 On all the walls of the house round about he carved engraved figures
of cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers, in the inner room and
in the outer. 30 The floor of the house he overlaid with gold, in the
inner room and in the outer. 31 For the entrance to the inner sanctuary
he made doors of olive wood. The lintel and the doorposts formed a
pentagon.[y] 32 He carved cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers on the
two doors of olive wood, and overlaid them with gold, hammering
the gold onto the cherubim and the palm trees. 33 So also he made for
the entrance of the main hall doorposts of olive wood, in the form of
a square,[z] 34 He made two doors of cypress wood. Each door had two
panels that folded, and each panel turned on a pivot. 35 On them he
carved cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers, and he overlaid them
with gold evenly applied on the carved work. 36 He built the inner
court with three rows of dressed stone and one row of cedar beams.[aa]
37 In the fourth year the foundation of the house of Yahweh was
laid, in the month of Ziv (April–May). 38 In the eleventh year, in the
month of Bul (October–November),[ab] the eighth month, the house

was completed in every detail and exactly as planned. He had spent seven years building it.

Notes

- a (6:1) The Septuagint reads "four hundred and fortieth year."
- b (6:1) Hebrew Ziv ("brightness," perhaps from the spring flowers), an older Canaanite month name. It is the second month of the spring-start religious calendar (later called Iyyar), so it fell in April–May; the exact modern dates varied from year to year with the lunar calendar. The Septuagint, in its addition at 6:1c, calls it Ziu.
- c (6:2) Hebrew "sixty cubits its length, twenty its width, and thirty cubits its height," about 27 by 9 by 13.5 meters. The cubit here is reckoned at about 18 inches (45 centimeters); a longer royal cubit of about 21 inches (52 centimeters) was also used (compare 2 Chronicles 3:3, "cubits of the old standard"), which would make the house about 105 by 35 by 52½ feet. The Septuagint reads "forty cubits in length, ... and its height twenty-five cubits."
- d (6:3) Hebrew hekal, "palace" or "temple," the large front room of the house, later called the Holy Place.
- e (6:3) Hebrew "twenty cubits," about 9 meters.
- f (6:3) Hebrew "ten cubits," about 4.5 meters.
- g (6:4) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. It may mean "windows with beveled frames," "latticed windows," or "windows narrowing inward."
- h (6:5) Hebrew debir, the innermost room, the Most Holy Place (verse 16). The word may come from a root meaning "back" (the rear room).
- i (6:6) Hebrew "five cubits ... six cubits ... seven cubits," about 2.3, 2.7, and 3.2 meters. Each story was wider than the one below because the main wall was stepped back at each level.
- j (6:8) Hebrew "middle." The Septuagint reads "the under side," which fits the sense.
- k (6:8) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. It may mean "trapdoors" or "shafts."
- l (6:10) Hebrew "five cubits," about 2.3 meters.
- m (6:11) The Septuagint lacks verses 11–14.
- n (6:15) Hebrew "walls," perhaps a scribal slip for the similar word for "beams" or "rafters" (the Septuagint reads "to the beams").
- o (6:15) Or "juniper" or "pine." The exact tree is uncertain.
- p (6:16) Hebrew "twenty cubits," about 9 meters.
- q (6:17) Hebrew "forty cubits," about 18 meters.
- r (6:18) The Septuagint lacks verse 18.
- s (6:20) Hebrew "twenty cubits in length, twenty cubits in width, and twenty cubits in its height," about 9 meters each way. The inner sanctuary was a cube; since the house was about 45 feet high (verse 2), the room may have stood on a raised floor or had a lower ceiling.

- t (6:20) Hebrew uncertain. This may be the altar of incense in front of the inner sanctuary (compare 7:48). The Septuagint reads "he made an altar," perhaps reading the Hebrew differently.
- u (6:23) Cherubim (singular cherub) were winged guardian figures associated with God's throne and presence (Exodus 25:18–22). The meaning of the word is uncertain.
- v (6:23) Hebrew "trees of oil," perhaps the wild olive or another resinous tree.
- w (6:23) Hebrew "ten cubits," about 4.5 meters.
- x (6:24) Hebrew "five cubits … five cubits … ten cubits," about 2.3 meters and 4.5 meters.
- y (6:31) Hebrew "fifth," probably a five-sided frame (a lintel shaped like a gable). The meaning is uncertain.
- z (6:33) Hebrew "from a fourth," probably meaning a four-sided (rectangular) frame. The meaning is uncertain.
- aa (6:36) After this verse the Septuagint adds "and he made the curtain of the court of the porch of the house that was in front of the temple" (6:36a). The Septuagint also places verses 37–38 earlier, in its addition after 5:18 (Hebrew 5:32), as 6:1c–d.
- ab (6:38) Hebrew Bul, an older Canaanite month name, perhaps meaning "produce" or "rain." It is the eighth month of the spring-start religious calendar (later called Marcheshvan), so it fell in October–November; the exact modern dates varied with the lunar calendar. The Septuagint addition at 6:1d calls it Baal.

Chapter 7

1 His own house Solomon was thirteen years in building, until he had
completed all of it. 2 He built the House of the Forest of Lebanon.[a] Its
length was about 150 feet, its width about 75 feet, and its height about
45 feet.[b] It stood on four rows of cedar pillars, with cedar beams laid
upon the pillars. 3 It was roofed with cedar over the side chambers
that rested on the pillars, forty-five in number, fifteen to a row. 4 There
were window frames in three rows, and window faced window in
three tiers. 5 All the doorways and doorposts had square frames, and
window faced window in three tiers.[c] 6 He made the Hall of Pillars
about 75 feet long and about 45 feet wide.[d] There was a porch in front
of them, with pillars and a canopy in front of them. 7 He built the
Hall of the Throne, where he would give judgment; this was the Hall
of Judgment. It was covered with cedar from one side of the floor to
the other.[e] 8 The house where he himself would dwell, in the other
court behind the hall, was of the same workmanship. And for the

daughter of Pharaoh, whom Solomon had married, he built a house like this hall.

9 All these were of costly stones, hewn according to measure, sawed with saws inside and outside, from the foundation up to the coping, and on the outside as far as the great court. 10 The foundation was of costly stones, great stones, some about 15 feet and some about 12 feet.[f] 11 Above them were costly stones, hewn according to measure, and cedar. 12 The great court had around it three courses of dressed stone and a course of cedar beams, just as the inner court of the house of Yahweh and the porch of the house had.

13 King Solomon sent and brought Hiram[g] from Tyre. 14 He was the son of a widow from the tribe of Naphtali,[h] and his father was a man of Tyre, a craftsman in bronze. He was full of wisdom, understanding, and knowledge for doing every kind of work in bronze. He came to King Solomon and did all his work.

15 He cast two pillars of bronze. Each pillar was about 27 feet high, and a line of about 18 feet measured its circumference.[i] 16 Two capitals of molten bronze he made as well, for placing on the pillars' tops; the height of each capital was about 7½ feet.[j] 17 For the capitals on top of the pillars he made nets of interwoven lattice and festoons of chainwork, seven[k] on one capital and seven on the other. 18 He made the pomegranates[l] in two rows around the one network to cover the capital on top of the pillar, and did the same for the other capital. 19 The capitals on top of the pillars in the portico were shaped like lilies, about 6 feet high.[m] 20 The capitals on the two pillars also had pomegranates above, next to the rounded part that was beside the lattice work. There were two hundred pomegranates in rows all around on each capital.[n] 21 He erected the pillars at the porch of the main hall. The one on the right he set up and named Jachin,[o] and the one on the left he set up and named Boaz.[p] 22 On the tops of the pillars was lily work. So the work of the pillars was finished.

23 Then he made the Sea[q] of cast metal. It was round, about 15 feet from brim to brim and about 7½ feet high, and a line of about 45 feet would encircle it.[r] 24 Gourds surrounded the Sea below its rim, ten gourds in every 18 inches,[s] encircling it all the way around. The gourds were in

two rows and were cast in one piece with the Sea. 25 It rested on twelve
oxen: three looked north, three looked west, three looked south, and
three looked east. The Sea was upon them, and their hind parts all
pointed inward. 26 Its thickness was about 3 inches,[t] and its brim was
made like the brim of a cup, like the flower of a lily. It held about
11,500 gallons.[u]
27 He also made the ten stands of bronze. Each stand was about 6 feet
long, about 6 feet wide, and about 4½ feet high.[v] 28 This was how the
stands were made: they had panels, and the panels were set between
the frames. 29 On the panels between the frames were figures of lions,
oxen, and cherubim, and so too on the frames; above and beneath
the lions and oxen were wreaths of hanging work. 30 Each stand had
four bronze wheels with bronze axles, and at its four corners were
supports. The supports were cast below the basin, with wreaths on
each side. 31 Its opening inside the crown, which projected upward,
was about 18 inches[w] deep. Its opening was round, as a pedestal
is made, about 27 inches[x] across. At its opening there were also
carvings, and its panels were square, not round. 32 The four wheels
were underneath the panels, and the axles of the wheels were part of
the stand. Each wheel was about 27 inches high. 33 The wheels were
built like chariot wheels. Their axles, rims, spokes, and hubs were all
cast metal. 34 Each stand had four supports, at its four corners, and
the supports were cast as part of the stand itself. 35 At the top of the
stand there was a round band about 9 inches[y] high, and on the top
of the stand its handles and its panels were of one piece with it. 36 On
the surfaces of its handles and on its panels he engraved cherubim,
lions, and palm trees, according to the space on each, with wreaths
all around. 37 In this way he made the ten stands. All of them had one
casting, one measure, and one shape.
38 He made ten basins of bronze. Each basin held about 230 gallons,[z]
and each basin measured about 6 feet.[aa] There was a basin on each of
the ten stands. 39 Five of the stands he placed on the south side of the
house and five on its north side, and the Sea he placed on the south
side of the house, toward the southeast.

40 Hiram also made the pots,[ab] the shovels, and the bowls. So Hiram
completed all the work he was doing for King Solomon in Yahweh's
house: 41 two pillars; two bowl-shaped capitals on top of the pillars;
two networks to cover the bowl-shaped capitals on top of the pillars;
42 four hundred pomegranates for the two networks, two rows of
pomegranates on each network, covering the bowl-shaped capitals
on the pillars; 43 the ten stands and the ten basins on the stands; 44
the one Sea and the twelve oxen under the Sea; 45 and the pots, the
shovels, and the bowls. All these vessels that Hiram made for King
Solomon in the house of Yahweh were of burnished bronze. 46 In the
plain of the Jordan the king cast them, in the clay ground between
Succoth[ac] and Zarethan. 47 Solomon left all the vessels unweighed
because there were so very many of them. The weight of the bronze
was not determined.
48 Solomon made all the furnishings that were in the house of Yahweh:
the altar of gold; the table of gold for the bread of the Presence; 49 the
lampstands of pure gold before the inner sanctuary, five at the right
and five at the left; the flowers, the lamps, and the tongs of gold; 50 the
cups, the snuffers, the bowls, the dishes for incense, and the fire pans,
of pure gold; and the sockets for the doors of the inner house, the
Most Holy Place, and for the doors of the main hall of the house, of
gold. 51 When all the work King Solomon had done for Yahweh's house
was complete, he brought in what his father David had dedicated, the
silver, the gold, and the articles, and placed them in the storerooms
of Yahweh's house.

Notes

- a (7:2) Probably so called because of its many cedar pillars from Lebanon, which made the hall look like a forest. Lebanon means "white," from its snow-covered mountains.
- b (7:2) Hebrew "a hundred cubits ... fifty cubits ... thirty cubits," about 45 by 22.5 by 13.5 meters.
- c (7:5) The meaning of the Hebrew of verses 4–5 is uncertain.
- d (7:6) Hebrew "fifty cubits ... thirty cubits," about 22.5 by 13.5 meters.
- e (7:7) Some ancient witnesses read "to the rafters" (compare 6:16). The Hebrew is uncertain.

- f (7:10) Hebrew "stones of ten cubits and stones of eight cubits," about 4.5 and 3.6 meters.
- g (7:13) Hebrew Hiram; also spelled Huram or Huram-abi in 2 Chronicles 2:13–14; 4:11. He is a craftsman, not the king of Tyre (5:1).
- h (7:14) 2 Chronicles 2:14 says his mother was from the tribe of Dan. She may have been of Danite descent but living in Naphtali, or the traditions differ.
- i (7:15) Hebrew "eighteen cubits was the height of each pillar, and a line of twelve cubits went around it," about 8.1 meters high and 5.4 meters around, giving a diameter of nearly 6 feet (1.7 meters). The Septuagint reads "fourteen cubits" for the circumference and adds that the fluting was four fingers wide (compare Jeremiah 52:21, which says the bronze was four fingers thick, about 3 inches or 7.5 centimeters, and that the pillars were hollow). It also adds "and thus was the other pillar formed."
- j (7:16) Hebrew "five cubits," about 2.3 meters. 2 Kings 25:17 gives three cubits.
- k (7:17) Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "a net" for "seven."
- l (7:18) Hebrew "he made the pillars." The words "pillars" and "pomegranates" appear to have been exchanged in this verse. The translation follows the sense.
- m (7:19) Hebrew "four cubits," about 1.8 meters. The detail may refer to the lily-shaped tops of the capitals.
- n (7:20) Hebrew "on the second capital"; the translation follows the sense of verse 42.
- o (7:21) Jachin means "he will establish" or "he establishes."
- p (7:21) Boaz probably means "in him is strength" or "with strength." The meanings of the two names together may form a sentence, such as "He [God] will establish [the throne] in strength."
- q (7:23) The Sea was a large basin for the priests to wash in (2 Chronicles 4:6).
- r (7:23) Hebrew "ten cubits from its brim to its brim … five cubits its height, and a line of thirty cubits would go around it," about 4.5 meters across, 2.3 meters high, and 13.5 meters around. The figures are round numbers; the circumference may have been measured below a flared rim. The Septuagint reads "thirty-three cubits."
- s (7:24) Hebrew "ten to a cubit," that is, ten for every 18 inches (45 centimeters).
- t (7:26) Hebrew "a handbreadth," about 3 inches or 7.5 centimeters. The Septuagint reads "a span."
- u (7:26) Hebrew "two thousand baths." A bath was a liquid measure of about 6 gallons (22 liters), so about 44,000 liters. The size of the bath is not certain, and estimates of the capacity vary widely. 2 Chronicles 4:5 gives "three thousand baths." The Septuagint here lacks the statement of capacity.
- v (7:27) Hebrew "four cubits … four cubits … three cubits," about 1.8 by 1.8 by 1.4 meters. The Septuagint reads "five cubits … four cubits … six cubits."
- w (7:31) Hebrew "a cubit," about 45 centimeters.
- x (7:31) Hebrew "a cubit and a half," about 68 centimeters; also in verse 32.
- y (7:35) Hebrew "half a cubit," about 23 centimeters.

- z (7:38) Hebrew “forty baths,” about 880 liters.
- aa (7:38) Hebrew “four cubits,” about 1.8 meters, probably the diameter.
- ab (7:40) The Septuagint (“caldrons”) and 2 Chronicles 4:11 read “pots”; the Masoretic text reads “basins” (the same word as in verse 38), apparently by a slip of one letter.
- ac (7:46) Succoth means “booths” or “shelters.” Zarethan has not been identified with certainty.

Chapter 8

1 Then Solomon gathered to himself in Jerusalem the elders of Israel
and all the heads of the tribes, the chiefs of the fathers’ houses of the
Israelites, to King Solomon, to bring the ark of Yahweh’s covenant up
out of the city of David, which is Zion.[a] 2 All the men of Israel gathered
to King Solomon at the feast in the month of Ethanim (September–
October),[b] which is the seventh month. 3 When all the elders of Israel
had come, the priests lifted up the ark. 4 They brought up the ark of
Yahweh, the tent of meeting, and all the holy vessels that were in the
tent; the priests and the Levites brought them up. 5 King Solomon and
the whole assembly of Israel, who had gathered around him in front
of the ark, sacrificed so many sheep and cattle that they could not be
counted or numbered. 6 Then the priests brought the ark of Yahweh’s
covenant to its place, into the inner sanctuary of the house, to the
Most Holy Place, beneath the wings of the cherubim. 7 The cherubim
stretched their two wings above the ark’s place, and the cherubim
made a covering above the ark and its poles. 8 The poles were so long
that a person in the Holy Place, before the inner sanctuary, could see
their ends, though no one outside could see them. And there they
remain to this day. 9 Nothing was in the ark but the two stone tablets
that Moses placed in it at Horeb,[c] when Yahweh made a covenant
with the Israelites as they came out of the land of Egypt. 10 And when
the priests came out of the Holy Place, the cloud filled the house of
Yahweh, 11 and the priests could not stand to minister because of the
cloud, for the glory of Yahweh filled Yahweh’s house.
12 Then Solomon said, “Yahweh has said that he would dwell in thick
darkness. 13 I have surely built you an exalted house, a place for you
to dwell in forever.”[d]

14 Then the king turned his face around and blessed all the assembly
of Israel, while all the assembly of Israel stood. 15 He said, "Blessed be
Yahweh, the God of Israel, who spoke with his own mouth to David
my father, and with his own hand has fulfilled it, saying, 16 'From the
day I brought my people Israel out of Egypt, I chose no city among
all Israel's tribes for building a house where my name might be. But
I chose David to be over my people Israel.'[e] 17 It was in the heart of
David my father to build a house for the name of Yahweh, the God
of Israel. 18 But Yahweh said to David my father, 'Since it was in your
heart to build a house for my name, you did well that it was in your
heart. 19 But you will not be the one to build the house. Your own son,
born to you, will build the house for my name.' 20 Now Yahweh has
fulfilled the word that he spoke. I have risen up in the place of David
my father and sit on the throne of Israel, as Yahweh promised, and
I have built the house for the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel. 21
And there I have made a place for the ark, in which is the covenant
of Yahweh that he made with our fathers when he brought them out
of the land of Egypt."
22 Then Solomon stood before the altar of Yahweh in the presence of
all the assembly of Israel and spread out his hands toward heaven,
23 and he said, "Yahweh, God of Israel, there is no God like you, in
heaven above or on earth beneath, who keeps covenant and faithful
love with your servants who walk before you with all their heart, 24
who have kept for your servant David my father what you declared
to him. With your mouth you spoke, and with your hand you have
fulfilled it, as it is this day. 25 So now, Yahweh, God of Israel, keep
the promise you made to my father David your servant when you
said, 'You will never lack a man to sit before me on Israel's throne,
provided your descendants watch their conduct and walk before me
as you have.' 26 And now, God of Israel, let the word you spoke to your
servant my father David come true.
27 "But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Look, heaven and the
highest heaven[f] cannot contain you; how much less this house that
I have built! 28 Yet turn toward the prayer of your servant and his
plea, Yahweh my God, to listen to the cry and the prayer that your

servant prays before you today, 29 May your eyes be open toward this
house night and day, toward the place about which you said, 'My
name will be there,' that you may hear the prayer that your servant
prays facing this place. 30 Listen to the plea of your servant and of
your people Israel when they pray toward this place. Hear in heaven,
your dwelling place; and when you hear, forgive.
31 "If a man sins against his neighbor and an oath is laid on him to
make him swear, and he comes and swears before your altar in this
house, 32 then hear in heaven and act. Judge between your servants:
declare the wicked guilty and bring his way upon his own head, and
declare the righteous innocent and give to him as his righteousness
deserves.
33 "When your people Israel are struck down before an enemy because
they have sinned against you, and they turn again to you and confess
your name and pray and plead with you in this house, 34 then hear in
heaven and forgive the sin of your people Israel, and bring them back
to the land that you gave to their fathers.
35 "When the heavens are shut up and there is no rain because they
have sinned against you, and they pray toward this place and confess
your name and turn from their sin, when you afflict them, 36 then listen
in heaven and forgive the sin of your servants, your people Israel.
Teach them the good way to live, and send rain on your land, which
you gave your people as an inheritance.
37 "When there is famine in the land, or plague, blight, mildew, locusts,
or grasshoppers,[g] or when their enemy besieges them in the land of
their cities,[h] or any kind of plague or sickness, 38 then whatever prayer
or plea comes from any person or from your whole people Israel,
as each one knows the plague of his own heart and stretches out
his hands toward this house, 39 then listen in heaven, your dwelling
place, forgive, and take action. Repay each person according to all his
conduct, since you know his heart (for you alone know the hearts of
all human beings), 40 so that they may fear you all the days that they
live in the land that you gave to our fathers.
41 "Also, when a foreigner who does not belong to your people Israel
comes from a faraway country because of your name 42 (for they shall

hear of your great name, of your strong hand and outstretched arm), and he comes and prays toward this house, 43 then listen from heaven, your dwelling place, and grant everything the foreigner calls out to you for, so that all the peoples of the earth may know your name and revere you, as your own people Israel do, and may know that this house I built bears your name.

44 "If your people go out to war against their enemy, wherever you send them, and they pray to Yahweh in the direction of the city you chose and of the house I built for your name, 45 then hear from heaven what they pray and plead, and maintain their cause.

46 "If they sin against you (for no human being is without sin), and you are angry with them and hand them over to the enemy, so that their captors carry them off to the enemy's land, far away or near, 47 and if in the land of their captivity they come to their senses,[i] repent, and appeal to you in the land of those who hold them, saying, 'We have sinned, we have done wrong, and we have been wicked,' 48 if they return to you wholeheartedly, with all their soul, in the land of the enemies who took them captive, and pray to you facing their land, which you gave their ancestors, the city you chose, and the house I built to honor your name, 49 then from heaven, where you dwell, hear what they pray and plead, and maintain their cause, 50 and pardon your people who sinned against you, and every transgression of theirs against you, and cause their captors to look on them with pity, so that they show them mercy 51 (for they are your people and your inheritance, whom you brought out of Egypt, from the midst of the iron furnace). 52 May your eyes be open to your servant's plea and to your people Israel's plea, so that you listen whenever they cry to you. 53 For you separated them from among all the peoples of the earth to be your inheritance, as you declared through Moses your servant, when you brought our fathers out of Egypt, Lord Yahweh."[j]

54 When Solomon had finished offering all this prayer and plea to Yahweh, he arose from before the altar of Yahweh, where he had knelt with his hands spread out toward heaven. 55 He stood and blessed all the assembly of Israel with a loud voice, saying, 56 "Blessed be Yahweh, who has given his people Israel rest, just as he promised.

Of all the good promises he made through his servant Moses, not
a single word has failed. 57 May Yahweh our God be with us, as he
was with our fathers. May he not leave us or forsake us, 58 that he
may incline our hearts to himself, to walk in all his ways and to
keep his commandments, his statutes, and his judgments, which he
commanded our fathers. 59 Let these words of mine, with which I have
pleaded before Yahweh, be near to Yahweh our God day and night,
that he may uphold the cause of his servant and the cause of his
people Israel, as each day requires, 60 so that all the peoples of the
earth may know that Yahweh is God; there is no other. 61 So let your
hearts be whole with Yahweh our God, to walk in his statutes and
keep his commandments, as you do today."
62 Then the king, and all Israel with him, offered sacrifice before
Yahweh. 63 Solomon offered as peace offerings to Yahweh twenty-two
thousand oxen and a hundred and twenty thousand sheep. So the
king and all the Israelites dedicated the house of Yahweh. 64 On that
same day the king consecrated the middle of the courtyard in front
of Yahweh's house. There he offered the burnt offering, the grain
offering, and the fat of the peace offerings, because the bronze altar
in Yahweh's presence was too small for the burnt offering, the grain
offering, and the fat of the peace offerings.
65 So Solomon held the feast at that time, and all Israel with him,
a great assembly from Lebo-hamath[k] to the Brook of Egypt,[l] before
Yahweh our God, seven days and another seven days, fourteen days.[m]
66 On the eighth day he sent the people away, and they blessed the king
and went to their tents joyful and glad of heart for all the goodness
that Yahweh had shown to David his servant and to Israel his people.

Notes

- a (8:1) Zion was originally the name of the fortified hill of the Jebusite city that David captured (2 Samuel 5:7). Its meaning is uncertain; it may mean "fortress" or "dry place." The Septuagint reads more briefly, "When Solomon had finished building the house of Yahweh and his own house after twenty years, King Solomon assembled all the elders of Israel in Zion, to bring up the ark …"
- b (8:2) Hebrew Ethanim, an older Canaanite month name meaning "ever-flowing" (perhaps of streams that run all year, or of the rains that begin at this season). It is the seventh month of the spring-start religious calendar (later called

Tishri), so it fell in September–October; the exact modern dates varied with the lunar calendar. The feast is the Feast of Booths (Leviticus 23:33–36). The Septuagint calls the month Athanin.

- c (8:9) Horeb is another name for Mount Sinai. It means "dry" or "desolate."
- d (8:13) The Septuagint places verses 12–13, in a different and longer form, after verse 53 (8:53a): "Then Solomon spoke concerning the house, when he had finished building it: 'He set the sun in the heavens; Yahweh said he would dwell in darkness. Build my house, a splendid house for yourself, to dwell in anew.' Is this not written in the Book of the Song?" Many scholars think "Song" (Hebrew shir) arose from a misreading of yashar, so that this is a reference to the Book of Jashar (compare Joshua 10:13; 2 Samuel 1:18).
- e (8:16) The Septuagint adds "and I chose Jerusalem, that my name might be there," as in 2 Chronicles 6:5–6.
- f (8:27) Hebrew "the heaven of heavens."
- g (8:37) Hebrew hasil, an insect, perhaps a kind of locust at a later stage of growth.
- h (8:37) Hebrew "in the land of his gates." The Septuagint reads "in one of their cities."
- i (8:47) Hebrew "return to their heart."
- j (8:53) The Septuagint adds the verses described in the note at verse 13.
- k (8:65) Or "from the entrance of Hamath," a town or pass on Israel's northern frontier. Lebo may mean "entrance."
- l (8:65) The Brook of Egypt is probably the Wadi el-Arish, on the southwestern border of Canaan.
- m (8:65) Hebrew "seven days and seven days, fourteen days," that is, the seven days of the dedication and the seven days of the Feast of Booths (compare 2 Chronicles 7:8–10). The Septuagint reads only "seven days."

Chapter 9

1 When Solomon had finished building the house of Yahweh and the
king's house and everything Solomon longed and desired to make,
2 Yahweh appeared to Solomon a second time, as he had appeared
to him at Gibeon.[a] 3 Yahweh told him, "I have heard the prayer and
plea you made to me. I have set this house you built apart as holy,
putting my name there forever. My eyes and my heart will always
be there. 4 As for you, if you walk before me as your father David
did, with a sincere heart and in uprightness, doing everything I have
commanded you and observing my laws and rulings, 5 I will set up
your royal throne over Israel forever, as I promised your father David:
'A man from your line will never be missing from the throne of Israel.'
6 But if you or your sons turn back from following me at all, and do

not keep my commandments and my statutes that I set before you,
but go off and serve other gods and bow down to them, 7 then I will
cut Israel off from the face of the ground that I gave them, and the
house that I have made holy for my name I will cast away from my
presence. Israel will become a proverb and a taunt among all peoples.
8 And though this house is now exalted, it will become a ruin,[b] and all
who pass by it will be astonished and hiss, and they will say, 'Why has
Yahweh done this to this land and to this house?' 9 Then people will
say, 'It is because they abandoned Yahweh their God, who brought
their ancestors out of Egypt, and clung to other gods, worshiping
and serving them. That is why Yahweh brought all this disaster on
them.' "[c]
10 At the end of twenty years, in which Solomon had built the two
houses, the house of Yahweh and the king's house, 11 Hiram king of
Tyre had furnished Solomon with cedar and cypress wood and with
gold, all that he desired; so then King Solomon gave Hiram twenty
towns in the land of Galilee.[d] 12 But when Hiram came out from Tyre
to see the towns Solomon had given him, they did not please him. 13
"What are these towns you have given me, my brother?" he said. So
they are called the land of Cabul[e] to this day. 14 Now Hiram had sent
the king about 9,000 pounds of gold.[f]
15 Here is the record of the labor force[g] King Solomon raised for build-
ing Yahweh's house and his own house, the Millo,[h] and Jerusalem's
wall, and Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer. 16 (Pharaoh king of Egypt
had come up and taken Gezer and set it on fire, putting to death
the Canaanites living there, and he had given the city as a parting
gift to his daughter, Solomon's wife; 17 so Solomon rebuilt Gezer.)
He also built Lower Beth-horon,[i] 18 Baalath, and Tamar[j] in the wilder-
ness, in the land, 19 all the storage cities Solomon owned, the cities
for his chariots and for his horsemen, and whatever else Solomon
wanted to build in Jerusalem, in Lebanon, and in all the territory he
governed. 20 As for all the people who were left of the Amorites, the
Hittites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites, who were not
of the Israelites, 21 their descendants who were left after them in the
land, whom the Israelites had been unable to devote to destruction,

Solomon made them a force of slave labor, as they are to this day. 22 But of the Israelites Solomon made no one a slave. They were the soldiers, his officials, his commanders, his officers,[k] and the commanders of his chariots and his horsemen. 23 These were the chief officials in charge of Solomon's projects: 550 who supervised the people doing the work.
24 As soon as Pharaoh's daughter moved up from David's city into the house Solomon built for her, he built the Millo.
25 Three times a year Solomon offered burnt offerings and peace offerings on the altar he had built to Yahweh, burning incense with them[l] before Yahweh. So he completed the house.
26 King Solomon also made a fleet of ships in Ezion-geber,[m] beside Eloth[n] on the coast of the Red Sea,[o] in Edomite land. 27 And Hiram sent with the fleet his servants, seamen who knew the sea, together with Solomon's servants. 28 They sailed to Ophir and took from there about 31,500 pounds of gold,[p] and brought it to King Solomon.

Notes

- a (9:2) Gibeon means "hill." See 3:4–5.
- b (9:8) So some ancient witnesses (compare the Syriac and Old Latin), reading le'iyyin. The Hebrew reads "will be high" ('elyon), perhaps meaning "however exalted this house is"; the Septuagint has "this house, which is high."
- c (9:9) The Septuagint adds (9:9a): "Then Solomon brought Pharaoh's daughter up out of the city of David into his house, which he had built for himself in those days." Compare verse 24 and 2:35c.
- d (9:11) Galilee means "circle" or "district," short for "the district of the nations" (Isaiah 9:1).
- e (9:13) Cabul sounds like the Hebrew for "as nothing" or "good for nothing." A town named Cabul is mentioned in Joshua 19:27. The Septuagint renders the name "Boundary."
- f (9:14) Hebrew "one hundred and twenty talents," about 4,080 kilograms. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- g (9:15) The Septuagint lacks verses 15–25 here. Parts of them appear in its additions at 2:35 and at 10:22a–c.
- h (9:15) The Millo ("filling") was probably a terraced or filled structure on the slope of the city of David.
- i (9:17) Beth-horon means "house of the hollow" or perhaps "house of Horon," a Canaanite god.
- j (9:18) So the Hebrew written text (Ketiv). The Hebrew reading tradition (Qere) reads Tadmor, as in 2 Chronicles 8:4, the oasis city later known as Palmyra. Tamar means "palm tree"; it was in the south of Judah (Ezekiel 47:19).

- k (9:22) Or "his captains," perhaps the third man in a chariot.
- l (9:25) Hebrew "burning incense with it, that which was before Yahweh." The meaning is uncertain.
- m (9:26) Ezion-geber may mean "backbone of a man," perhaps a ridge near the town.
- n (9:26) Also called Elath, meaning "terebinths" or "tall trees."
- o (9:26) Hebrew "the Sea of Reeds," here the Gulf of Aqaba.
- p (9:28) Hebrew "four hundred and twenty talents," about 14,280 kilograms. The Septuagint reads "one hundred and twenty talents." Ophir was a land famed for its gold; its location is uncertain.

Chapter 10

1 Now the queen of Sheba[a] heard of Solomon's fame on account of the
name of Yahweh,[b] and she came to put him to the test with riddles.
2 She arrived in Jerusalem with a very great retinue, with camels
carrying spices and a vast quantity of gold and precious stones. She
came in to Solomon and talked with him of all that was in her heart. 3
Solomon answered all her questions; nothing was too difficult for the
king to explain to her. 4 When the queen of Sheba saw all Solomon's
wisdom, the house he had built, 5 the food of his table, the seating
of his officials, the attendance of his servants and their clothing,
his cupbearers, and the burnt offerings[c] he offered at the house of
Yahweh, it took her breath away.[d] 6 She said to the king, "The report I
heard in my own land about your words and your wisdom was true.
7 But I did not believe what was said until I came and saw it with my
own eyes. And look, not even half was told me. Your wisdom and
prosperity go beyond the report that I heard. 8 How happy your men[e]
must be! How happy these servants of yours, who stand continually
before you and hear your wisdom! 9 Blessed be Yahweh your God,
who took pleasure in you, to place you on Israel's throne! It is because
of Yahweh's everlasting love for Israel that he has made you king, to
do justice and righteousness." 10 Then she gave the king about 9,000
pounds of gold,[f] a very great amount of spices, and precious stones.
Never again did spices arrive in such abundance as those the queen
of Sheba gave to King Solomon.
11 Moreover, the fleet of Hiram that brought gold from Ophir carried
from there almug wood[g] in great abundance, and precious stones. 12

The king used the almug wood for supports[h] in Yahweh's house and
in the king's house, and for making lyres and harps for the singers.
Never since has such almug wood arrived, nor has any been seen
to this day. 13 King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba everything she
desired, whatever she asked, besides what he gave her out of his royal
bounty.[i] Then she turned and went back to her own land, she and her
servants.
14 The weight of gold that came to Solomon in one year was about
50,000 pounds,[j] 15 besides what came from the traders, the business
of the merchants, and all the kings of Arabia[k] and the governors of
the land. 16 King Solomon made two hundred great shields of beaten
gold; about 15 pounds of gold[l] went into each shield. 17 He also made
three hundred small shields of hammered gold; about 3¾ pounds of
gold[m] went into each shield. And the king put them in the House of
the Forest of Lebanon. 18 The king also made a great throne of ivory
and overlaid it with the finest gold. 19 The throne had six steps, and its
back was rounded at the top.[n] Armrests were on each side of the seat,
and a lion stood next to each armrest, 20 On the six steps were twelve
lions, a lion at each end of every step. Nothing like it was ever made
in any kingdom. 21 All King Solomon's drinking vessels were of gold,
and all the vessels of the House of the Forest of Lebanon were of pure
gold. None were of silver; it was thought of as nothing in Solomon's
days. 22 The king had a fleet of Tarshish ships[o] on the sea together
with Hiram's fleet. Every three years the Tarshish fleet returned with
a cargo of gold, silver, ivory, apes, and baboons.[p]
23 So King Solomon surpassed all the kings of the earth in riches and
in wisdom. 24 And the whole earth was seeking Solomon's presence,
to listen to the wisdom God had placed in his heart. 25 Year after
year, each one brought a gift of silver and gold articles, garments,
weapons,[q] spices, horses, and mules.
26 Solomon assembled chariots and horses. He had 1,400 chariots and
12,000 horses,[r] which he kept in the chariot cities and near him in
Jerusalem. 27 The king made silver as plentiful in Jerusalem as stones,
and cedar as abundant as sycamore-fig trees in the Shephelah.[s] 28
Solomon's horses were imported from Egypt[t] and from Kue;[u] the

king's traders received them from Kue at a price. [29] A chariot could be imported from Egypt for about 15 pounds of silver[v] and a horse for about 3¾ pounds.[w] In the same way they exported them through these traders to all the kings of the Hittites and the kings of Aram.

Notes

- a (10:1) Sheba was a kingdom in southwestern Arabia (modern Yemen), whose people traded in spices and incense.
- b (10:1) The phrase is difficult; the Septuagint reads "the name of Solomon and the name of Yahweh."
- c (10:5) Or "the ascent by which he went up." The Hebrew word ʿolato can mean either; 2 Chronicles 9:4 reads "his upper chamber" or "his ascent."
- d (10:5) Hebrew "there was no more spirit in her."
- e (10:8) So the Hebrew. The Septuagint and Syriac read "your wives," a difference of one vowel and one letter in Hebrew.
- f (10:10) Hebrew "one hundred and twenty talents," about 4,080 kilograms. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- g (10:11) Almug wood (called algum wood in 2 Chronicles 2:8; 9:10–11) is an unknown kind of valuable wood, perhaps red sandalwood or juniper.
- h (10:12) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; it may mean "railings," "steps," or "inlay."
- i (10:13) Hebrew "according to the hand of King Solomon."
- j (10:14) Hebrew "six hundred and sixty-six talents of gold," about 22,600 kilograms.
- k (10:15) Hebrew haʿereb, here vocalized as "the mixed peoples" or "the west," but almost certainly meaning "Arabia" (ʿarab), as in 2 Chronicles 9:14; the Septuagint reads "of the country beyond the river."
- l (10:16) Hebrew "six hundred shekels," about 6.9 kilograms. A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams). The Septuagint has "three hundred spears of beaten gold; three hundred shekels of gold were on each spear."
- m (10:17) Hebrew "three minas," about 1.7 kilograms. A mina was about 1¼ pounds (575 grams). 2 Chronicles 9:16 reads "three hundred shekels."
- n (10:19) Hebrew "a round head was to the throne at its back." The Septuagint reads "calves in relief," reading ʿegel ("calf") for ʿagol ("round").
- o (10:22) Ships of Tarshish were large seagoing trading ships, named after Tarshish, a distant port probably in the western Mediterranean (perhaps Tartessus in Spain).
- p (10:22) Or "peacocks." The meaning of the Hebrew word tukkiyyim is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "wrought stones and hewn stones" and then adds 10:22a–c, a form of 9:15, 17–22.
- q (10:25) Or "myrrh." The Hebrew word nesheq usually means "weapons." The Septuagint reads "stacte" (a spice).
- r (10:26) Or "charioteers." The Septuagint reads "four thousand mares for his chariots and twelve thousand horsemen," and then adds (10:26a), "And he ruled

over all the kings from the River to the land of the Philistines and to the borders of Egypt" (compare 4:21 and 2 Chronicles 9:26).

- s (10:27) The Shephelah ("lowland") is the region of low hills between the hill country of Judah and the coastal plain.
- t (10:28) Some scholars read "from Musri," a region in Asia Minor near Kue, instead of Egypt (Hebrew Mitsrayim).
- u (10:28) Kue was Cilicia, in southeastern Asia Minor. The Septuagint reads "Thecue."
- v (10:29) Hebrew "six hundred shekels of silver," about 6.9 kilograms. The Septuagint reads "a hundred shekels of silver."
- w (10:29) Hebrew "one hundred and fifty shekels," about 1.7 kilograms. The Septuagint reads "fifty shekels of silver."

Chapter 11

1 But King Solomon loved many foreign women, together with
Pharaoh's daughter: women of Moab, of Ammon, of Edom, of Sidon,
and of the Hittites, 2 from the nations about which Yahweh had told
the Israelites, "You shall not go in among them, nor they among you,
for they will surely turn your heart aside after their gods." Solomon
clung to these in love. 3 He had 700 wives of royal birth and 300
concubines, and his wives drew his heart away.[a] 4 As Solomon grew
old, his wives turned his heart toward other gods, and his heart
was not fully devoted to Yahweh his God, as his father David's had
been. 5 Solomon followed Ashtoreth,[b] the goddess of the Sidonians,
and Milcom,[c] the abhorrent god of the Ammonites. 6 So Solomon did
evil in Yahweh's eyes; he did not fully follow Yahweh as his father
David had. 7 Then Solomon built a high place for Chemosh,[d] Moab's
abhorrent idol, on the hill east of Jerusalem,[e] and one for Molech,[f] the
abhorrent idol of the Ammonites. 8 He did the same for all his foreign
wives, who burned incense and sacrificed to their gods.
9 Yahweh was angry with Solomon because his heart had turned away
from Yahweh, the God of Israel, who had appeared to him twice 10 and
had commanded him concerning this very thing, that he should not
go after other gods. But he did not keep what Yahweh commanded. 11
So Yahweh told Solomon, "Because you have behaved this way,[g] and
have not kept my covenant and my laws, which I commanded you,
I will tear the kingdom away from you and give it to one of your

servants. 12 Nevertheless, in your lifetime I will not do it, for David your father's sake; out of your son's hand I will tear it. 13 Still, I will not tear away all the kingdom; one tribe I will give to your son, for David my servant's sake and for Jerusalem's sake, which I have chosen."
14 So Yahweh stirred up an adversary[h] for Solomon: Hadad[i] the Edomite, who was of the king's family in Edom. 15 For it happened, while David was in Edom and Joab, the army's commander, had gone up to bury the dead, that he killed every male in Edom 16 (Joab and all Israel remained there six months, until they had wiped out every male in Edom), 17 Hadad fled to Egypt with some Edomites of his father's servants, Hadad being still a small boy. 18 They set out from Midian and came to Paran,[j] and they took men with them from Paran and came to Egypt, to Pharaoh king of Egypt, who gave him a house, assigned him food, and gave him land. 19 Hadad found great favor in Pharaoh's sight, so that he gave him as wife the sister of his own wife, the sister of Tahpenes the queen. 20 Tahpenes's sister bore him a son, Genubath, whom Tahpenes raised in Pharaoh's palace. Genubath lived in the palace with Pharaoh's own sons. 21 But when Hadad heard in Egypt that David slept with his fathers and that Joab the commander of the army was dead, Hadad said to Pharaoh, "Let me go, so that I may go to my own country." 22 Pharaoh asked him, "What do you lack here with me that makes you want to return to your own country?" "Nothing," he answered, "but please let me go."
23 God also raised up another opponent against Solomon, Rezon[k] son of Eliada, who had run away from his master, Hadadezer king of Zobah. 24 He gathered men around him and became leader of a raiding band, after David killed them.[l] They went to Damascus and settled there and ruled in Damascus. 25 He opposed Israel all through Solomon's reign, adding to the trouble Hadad caused. He despised Israel and ruled over Aram.[m]
26 Jeroboam[n] son of Nebat, an Ephraimite from Zeredah, was one of Solomon's officials; his mother was a widow named Zeruah. He too rebelled against the king. 27 This is the story of how he raised his hand against the king. Solomon had built the Millo and had closed up the breach in the city of David his father. 28 Jeroboam was a man of ability,[o]

and when Solomon saw how hard the young man worked, he put him in charge of the whole forced-labor crew from the house of Joseph.
29 About that time, as Jeroboam was leaving Jerusalem, the prophet Ahijah[p] of Shiloh met him on the road. Ahijah was wearing a new cloak, and the two were alone out in the country. 30 Then Ahijah seized the new cloak that was on him and ripped it into twelve pieces. 31 And he said to Jeroboam, "Take for yourself ten pieces, because Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'See, I am tearing the kingdom from the hand of Solomon, and I will give you ten tribes. 32 But one tribe[q] will remain his, for David my servant's sake and for Jerusalem's sake, the city that I have chosen from among all Israel's tribes. 33 The reason is that they have abandoned me[r] and bowed to Ashtoreth, the Sidonian goddess, Chemosh, the god of Moab, and Milcom, the Ammonite god. They have not lived by my ways, doing what is right in my eyes and keeping my laws and rulings as David his father did. 34 Yet I will not take all the kingdom out of his hand. I will keep him as ruler as long as he lives, for the sake of my servant David, my chosen one, who kept my commandments and statutes. 35 From his son's hand, though, I will take the kingship and give ten tribes of it to you. 36 And one tribe I will give to his son, so that my servant David may have a lamp[s] before me always in Jerusalem, the city I chose for myself to place my name there. 37 You I will take, and you will rule over everything you desire; you will be king over Israel. 38 If you obey everything I command you, follow my ways, and do what is right in my eyes by keeping my laws and commands as my servant David did, then I will be with you. I will build you an enduring dynasty just as I built one for David, and I will give Israel to you. 39 So I will afflict the offspring of David for this, yet not for all time.' "[t] 40 Solomon therefore sought to kill Jeroboam, but Jeroboam arose and fled to Egypt, to Shishak[u] king of Egypt, and he stayed in Egypt until Solomon's death.
41 The rest of the acts of Solomon, all that he did, and his wisdom, are they not written in the Book of the Acts of Solomon? 42 The time that Solomon reigned in Jerusalem over all Israel was forty years. 43 Solomon slept with his fathers and was buried in the city of David his father. And Rehoboam[v] his son reigned in his place.[w]

Notes

- a (11:3) The Septuagint lacks "and his wives turned his heart aside."
- b (11:5) Ashtoreth (Astarte) was a Canaanite goddess of fertility and war. The Hebrew vowels may have been changed to those of bosheth, "shame."
- c (11:5) Milcom, the national god of Ammon, a name related to melek, "king." The Septuagint reads "their king."
- d (11:7) Chemosh was the national god of Moab; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- e (11:7) That is, the Mount of Olives; it was later called the Mount of Corruption (2 Kings 23:13).
- f (11:7) Molech is probably another form of Milcom (verse 5; compare verse 33). The Hebrew vowels may have been changed to those of bosheth, "shame."
- g (11:11) Hebrew "Because this was with you."
- h (11:14) Hebrew satan, "adversary, opponent."
- i (11:14) Hadad is the name of the Aramean storm god; it may mean "thunderer." The Septuagint calls him Ader.
- j (11:18) Midian lay east of the Gulf of Aqaba; Paran is the wilderness south of Judah in the Sinai.
- k (11:23) Rezon means "prince" or "ruler." The Septuagint lacks verses 23–24 as a separate account and instead mentions Rezon (Esrom) together with Hadad in verse 14.
- l (11:24) That is, after David defeated Hadadezer and his allies (2 Samuel 8:3–8; 10:15–19).
- m (11:25) Aram is Syria, with its capital at Damascus.
- n (11:26) Jeroboam may mean "may the people multiply" or "may the people contend."
- o (11:28) Hebrew gibbor hayil, "a mighty man of valor," here probably of ability and standing.
- p (11:29) Ahijah means "Yahweh is my brother." A Shilonite is a man of Shiloh ("tranquil"?), where the tabernacle had stood.
- q (11:32) That is, Judah, with which Benjamin was reckoned (12:21). The Septuagint reads "two tribes" here and in verse 36.
- r (11:33) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "he has forsaken me," and so in the rest of the verse.
- s (11:36) That is, a descendant on the throne; compare 15:4; 2 Kings 8:19.
- t (11:39) The Septuagint lacks verse 39.
- u (11:40) Shishak is Pharaoh Sheshonq I, founder of Egypt's Twenty-second Dynasty.
- v (11:43) Rehoboam means "the people are enlarged" or "may the people be enlarged."
- w (11:43) The Septuagint adds a longer account of Jeroboam's return from Egypt here and in 12:2–3, and an alternative account of his rise at 12:24a–z.

Chapter 12

1 Rehoboam went to Shechem,[a] for all Israel had come to Shechem to
make him king. 2 When Jeroboam son of Nebat heard of it (he was still
in Egypt, where he had fled from King Solomon), Jeroboam lived on in
Egypt.[b] 3 They sent and called him, and Jeroboam and all the assembly
of Israel[c] came and spoke to Rehoboam, saying, 4 "Your father made
our yoke hard. Now lighten the hard service of your father and the
heavy yoke he laid on us, and we will serve you." 5 He said to them,
"Go away for three days, and then come back to me." So the people
went.

6 King Rehoboam took counsel with the old men who had stood
before Solomon his father while he was alive. "How do you advise
me to answer this people?" he asked. 7 They told him, "If today you
will be a servant to this people and serve them, and answer them by
speaking kind words to them, they will be your servants forever." 8
But he set aside the advice the old men gave him and took counsel
with the young men who had grown up with him and who stood
before him. 9 He asked them, "How do you advise us to answer these
people, who told me, 'Lighten the yoke that your father placed on
us'?" 10 The young men who had grown up with him told him, "Say
this to the people who told you, 'Your father made our yoke heavy,
but you lighten it for us': say to them, 'My little finger is thicker than
my father's waist![d] 11 And now, whereas my father laid a heavy yoke
on you, I will make your yoke heavier. My father punished you with
whips; I will punish you with scorpions.' "[e]

12 Jeroboam and all the people came to Rehoboam on the third day,
just as the king had said, "Return to me on the third day." 13 The king
answered the people harshly. He set aside the counsel the old men had
given him 14 and spoke to them as the young men had counseled: "My
father made your yoke heavy, and I will add to it. My father flogged
you with whips; I will flog you with scorpions." 15 So the king did
not listen to the people, for it was a turn of events brought about by
Yahweh, so that he might fulfill his word, which Yahweh had spoken
through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam son of Nebat.

16 When all Israel saw that the king refused to listen to them, the
people gave the king this reply: "What portion is ours in David? No
inheritance is ours in Jesse's son. Back to your tents, Israel! Now see
to your own house, David!" So Israel went away to their tents. 17 But as
for the Israelites who lived in the towns of Judah, Rehoboam reigned
over them.[f] 18 Then King Rehoboam sent Adoram,[g] the overseer of the
forced labor, but all Israel pelted him with stones until he died. King
Rehoboam hurried to mount his chariot and fled to Jerusalem. 19 Thus
Israel rebelled against David's house, and so it remains to this day.
20 When all Israel heard that Jeroboam had come back, they sent for
him, called him to the assembly, and made him king over all Israel.
Only the tribe of Judah remained loyal to David's house.
21 When Rehoboam arrived in Jerusalem, he assembled all the house
of Judah and the tribe of Benjamin, one hundred and eighty thousand
chosen warriors,[h] to fight against the house of Israel and restore the
kingdom to Rehoboam son of Solomon. 22 But the word of God came
to Shemaiah[i] the man of God: 23 "Say to Rehoboam son of Solomon,
king of Judah, and to all the house of Judah and Benjamin and the
rest of the people, 24 'This is what Yahweh says: Do not go up to make
war on your kinsmen the Israelites. Return, each man to his house,
because this has come about from me.' " So they listened to the word
of Yahweh and went home again, as Yahweh had said.[j]
25 Jeroboam then built up Shechem in Ephraim's hill country and
made his home there; and going out from there, he built up Penuel.[k]
26 And Jeroboam said in his heart, "Now the kingdom will go back
to the house of David. 27 If these people go up to offer sacrifices in
Yahweh's house at Jerusalem, their loyalty will return to their lord,
Rehoboam king of Judah. Then they will kill me and go back to
him." 28 After taking counsel, the king made two golden calves and
said to the people,[l] "It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem.
Look, Israel: your gods, that led you up out of Egypt's land!" 29 He
set one in Bethel,[m] and the other he put in Dan.[n] 30 This became a
sin, because the people traveled all the way to Dan to worship in
front of the one there.[o] 31 He also built shrines on high places and
appointed priests from every class of people, though they were not

Levites. 32 Jeroboam established a festival on the fifteenth day of the
eighth month (October–November),[p] like the festival held in Judah,
and he went up to the altar. This was at Bethel, where he sacrificed
to the calves he had made, and in Bethel he installed priests for the
high places he had made. 33 He went up to the altar he had made in
Bethel on the fifteenth day of the eighth month, in the month that he
had devised in his own heart. He instituted a feast for the Israelites
and went up to the altar to burn incense.

Notes

- a (12:1) Shechem means "shoulder" or "ridge"; it lay between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim.
- b (12:2) So the Hebrew (wayyesheb). 2 Chronicles 10:2 and some ancient witnesses read "Jeroboam returned from Egypt" (wayyashob). The Septuagint lacks verses 2–3a here (but see 11:43 and 12:24d–f).
- c (12:3) So the Hebrew reading tradition (Qere); the written text (Ketiv) has "and they came."
- d (12:10) Hebrew "my little one is thicker than my father's loins."
- e (12:11) Probably whips with barbs or metal tips.
- f (12:17) The Septuagint lacks verse 17.
- g (12:18) Adoram is a short form of Adoniram ("my lord is exalted"); see 4:6.
- h (12:21) The Septuagint reads "one hundred and twenty thousand."
- i (12:22) Shemaiah means "Yahweh has heard."
- j (12:24) The Septuagint adds a long alternative account of Rehoboam's accession and Jeroboam's rise and return (12:24a–z). In it Jeroboam's mother is a prostitute named Sarira, Jeroboam marries Ano, the sister of Pharaoh's wife, the story of his sick son (compare 14:1–18) comes before the assembly at Shechem, and the prophet who tears the garment is Shemaiah rather than Ahijah (compare 11:29–31).
- k (12:25) Penuel means "face of God" (Genesis 32:30); it was east of the Jordan on the Jabbok.
- l (12:28) So the Septuagint; the Hebrew reads "to them."
- m (12:29) Bethel means "house of God."
- n (12:29) Dan means "judge" or "he judged"; it lay at the northern edge of Israel.
- o (12:30) Hebrew "went before the one, as far as Dan." Some think words have dropped out, such as "to Bethel and before the other."
- p (12:32) Hebrew "in the eighth month," that is, Bul (6:38), later called Marcheshvan, of the spring-start calendar, one month after the Feast of Booths in Judah (8:2). The exact modern dates varied with the lunar calendar.

Chapter 13

1 And behold, a man of God came out of Judah by the word of Yahweh
to Bethel, while Jeroboam was standing by the altar to burn incense. 2
He cried out against the altar by the word of Yahweh: "Altar, altar, this
is what Yahweh says: 'A son named Josiah[a] will be born to David's
house. On you he will sacrifice the priests of the high places who now
burn incense on you, and human bones will be burned on you.' " 3 He
gave a sign the same day: "This is the sign that Yahweh has spoken:
the altar will split apart, and the ashes on it will spill out." 4 When
King Jeroboam heard what the man of God had cried out against the
altar in Bethel, he thrust out his hand from beside the altar, saying,
"Arrest him!" And the hand he had thrust out toward him withered,[b]
so that he was unable to pull it back. 5 The altar also was split apart,
and the ashes poured out from the altar, according to the sign the man
of God had given by the word of Yahweh. 6 Then the king said to the
man of God, "Please seek the favor of Yahweh your God and pray for
me, so that my hand is made well again." So the man of God sought
Yahweh's favor, and the king's hand was made well again and became
as it was before. 7 Then the king said to the man of God, "Come home
with me and refresh yourself, and I will give you a reward." 8 But the
man of God said to the king, "Though you should give me half of
your house, I would not go in with you; I will not eat bread or drink
water here. 9 For so I was commanded by the word of Yahweh: 'Eat
no bread, drink no water, and do not go back by the way you came.'
" 10 So he left by a different road and did not go back on the road by
which he had come to Bethel.

11 Now an old prophet lived in Bethel. His son[c] came and told him all
that the man of God had done that day in Bethel; and the words he
had spoken to the king, they told to their father as well. 12 Their father
asked, "Which road did he take?" His sons had seen[d] which road the
man of God from Judah had taken. 13 He said to his sons, "Saddle the
donkey for me." So they saddled the donkey for him, and he rode on
it. 14 He went after the man of God and found him sitting under an
oak. He said to him, "Are you the man of God who came from Judah?"
He answered, "I am." 15 Then he said to him, "Come home with me

and eat some bread." 16 He answered, "I cannot go back with you or
enter with you, and I will not eat bread or drink water with you in
this place, 17 for I was told by the word of Yahweh: 'You must not eat
bread or drink water there, and you must not go back the way you
came.' " 18 The old man said, "I am also a prophet, just as you are, and
an angel spoke to me by Yahweh's word, 'Bring him back with you
to your house, so that he may eat bread and drink water.' " But the
old man was lying to him. 19 So he went back with him and ate bread
in his house and drank water.
20 While they sat at the table, Yahweh's word came to the prophet who
had brought him back, 21 and he cried out to the man of God who
had come from Judah, "This is what Yahweh says: 'Because you have
defied the mouth of Yahweh and have not kept the command that
Yahweh your God gave you, 22 but you came back and ate bread and
drank water in the place where he told you not to eat or drink, your
body will not be buried in your ancestors' tomb.' " 23 After he had eaten
bread and drunk, the old prophet saddled the donkey for the prophet
he had brought back. 24 He went on his way, and a lion met him on the
road and killed him. His body was flung down in the road; the donkey
stood by it, and the lion too stood by the body. 25 Some men passing
by saw the body flung in the road and the lion standing next to it, and
they came and told it in the town where the old prophet lived. 26 The
prophet who had brought him back from his journey heard about it
and said, "That is the man of God who disobeyed Yahweh's command.
So Yahweh handed him over to the lion, which mauled and killed him,
as Yahweh's word to him had said."[e] 27 He told his sons, "Saddle the
donkey for me," and they saddled it. 28 He went and found the body
thrown on the road, with the donkey and the lion standing beside
the body. The lion had not eaten the body or mauled the donkey. 29
The prophet picked up the body of the man of God, laid it on the
donkey, and brought it back. The old prophet came into his town to
mourn and to bury him. 30 He laid the body in his own grave, and they
mourned over him, "Alas, my brother!" 31 When he had buried him,
he told his sons, "At my death, bury me in the same tomb as the man
of God; place my bones next to his.[f] 32 For the word he cried out by the

word of Yahweh against the altar in Bethel and against all the shrines of the high places in the towns of Samaria[g] will surely come to pass."
33 Even after this Jeroboam did not turn from his evil way, but again he made priests for the high places from all ranks of the people. Anyone who wished, he ordained[h] to be priests of the high places. 34 This became the sin of Jeroboam's house and led to its destruction, wiping it from the face of the earth.

Notes

- a (13:2) Josiah means "Yahweh supports" or "Yahweh heals." His reign and the fulfillment of this word are told in 2 Kings 22–23 (see 23:15–18).
- b (13:4) Hebrew "dried up."
- c (13:11) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "his sons."
- d (13:12) Hebrew "his sons had seen." The Septuagint reads "his sons showed him."
- e (13:26) The Septuagint lacks most of the second half of verse 26 and all of verse 27.
- f (13:31) The Septuagint adds "so that my bones may be preserved with his bones" (compare 2 Kings 23:18).
- g (13:32) Samaria, named in 16:24, was not founded until the reign of Omri. The phrase may reflect the later name of the northern region.
- h (13:33) Hebrew "he filled his hand."

Chapter 14

1 At that time Abijah[a] son of Jeroboam fell sick.[b] 2 Jeroboam told his wife, "Go and disguise yourself so that no one will recognize you as Jeroboam's wife, and travel to Shiloh. The prophet Ahijah lives there —the man who told me that I would rule this people. 3 Take with you ten loaves, some cakes, and a jar of honey, and go to him. He will tell you what will become of the boy." 4 Jeroboam's wife did so. She set out for Shiloh and arrived at Ahijah's house. Ahijah could not see, because his eyes had grown fixed[c] with age.

5 But Yahweh had said to Ahijah, "Jeroboam's wife is on her way to inquire of you about her son, since he is ill. Speak to her in this way. On coming in, she will be acting as if she were someone else."
6 So when Ahijah heard the sound of her feet as she came in at the door, he said, "Come in, wife of Jeroboam. Why do you pretend to be someone else? I have been sent to you with hard news. 7 Go, tell Jeroboam, 'This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: Because I lifted you up out of the people and made you ruler over my people

Israel, 8 I tore the kingdom away from the house of David and gave
it to you. Yet you have not been like my servant David, who kept
my commandments and followed me with all his heart, doing only
what was right in my eyes. 9 You have done worse than all your
predecessors: you went and made yourself other gods and cast metal
images to provoke me, and you turned your back on me. 10 So I will
bring disaster on Jeroboam's house. I will cut off from Jeroboam every
male,[d] slave or free, in Israel, and I will sweep away Jeroboam's house
as dung is swept away, until none of it is left. 11 Whoever of Jeroboam's
line dies in the city, dogs shall devour; whoever dies in the field, the
birds of the sky shall devour. For Yahweh has spoken.' 12 As for you,
get up and go home. When your feet enter the city, the child will die.
13 All Israel will mourn for him and bury him. He alone of Jeroboam's
family will come to a grave, because in him something pleasing to
Yahweh, the God of Israel, has been found in the house of Jeroboam.
14 And Yahweh will raise up for himself a king over Israel who will
cut off the house of Jeroboam on that day. What then? Even now![e]
15 Yahweh will strike Israel, as a reed is shaken in the water, and he
will root Israel up out of this good land that he gave their fathers and
disperse them beyond the Euphrates,[f] because they have made their
Asherah poles,[g] provoking Yahweh to anger. 16 He will give Israel up
because of the sins of Jeroboam, which he committed and which he
caused Israel to commit."
17 Then Jeroboam's wife got up and left and came to Tirzah.[h] As she
crossed the threshold of the house, the child died. 18 They buried him,
and all Israel mourned for him, according to the word of Yahweh,
which he spoke through his servant Ahijah the prophet.
19 As for the rest of Jeroboam's acts, how he fought and how he ruled,
they are written in the Book of the Chronicles[i] of the Kings of Israel.
20 Jeroboam reigned twenty-two years. Then he slept with his fathers,
and Nadab[j] his son reigned in his place.
21 Meanwhile Rehoboam son of Solomon reigned in Judah. Rehoboam
was forty-one years old when he became king, and he reigned
seventeen years in Jerusalem, the city Yahweh had chosen out of all
the tribes of Israel to put his name there. His mother's name was

Naamah[k] the Ammonite. 22 Judah did what was evil in Yahweh's
sight, and by the sins they committed they provoked him to jealousy
beyond all that their fathers had done. 23 For they also built for them-
selves high places, sacred stone pillars, and Asherah poles on every
high hill and under every green tree. 24 There were also male shrine
prostitutes[l] in the land. They did according to all the abominations of
the nations that Yahweh had driven out before the Israelites.
25 In King Rehoboam's fifth year, Shishak king of Egypt marched
against Jerusalem. 26 He carried off the treasures of Yahweh's house
and of the royal palace; he took everything, including all the gold
shields Solomon had made.[m] 27 King Rehoboam then made bronze
shields to replace them and entrusted them to the officers of the
guard,[n] who watched the entrance to the royal palace. 28 As often as
the king went into the house of Yahweh, the guard carried them and
then brought them back to the guardroom.
29 The rest of the acts of Rehoboam and all that he did, are they not
written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah? 30 There
was war between Rehoboam and Jeroboam continually. 31 Rehoboam
died and was buried with his ancestors in the City of David. His
mother was Naamah, an Ammonite. His son Abijam[o] became king
after him.

Notes

- a (14:1) Abijah means "Yahweh is my father."
- b (14:1) The Septuagint lacks verses 1–20 here; a different form of the story of the sick child appears in its addition at 12:24g–n.
- c (14:4) Hebrew "had stood," that is, had become rigid or sightless.
- d (14:10) Hebrew "every one who urinates against a wall," a coarse idiom for males.
- e (14:14) Hebrew "And what? Even now." The meaning is uncertain.
- f (14:15) Hebrew "the River."
- g (14:15) Asherah poles were wooden cult objects associated with the Canaanite goddess Asherah.
- h (14:17) Tirzah means "pleasantness" or "delight." It served as the capital of the northern kingdom until Omri built Samaria (16:23–24).
- i (14:19) Hebrew "the Book of the Matters of the Days," the official royal annals, here and throughout Kings.
- j (14:20) Nadab means "generous" or "willing."

- k (14:21) Naamah means “pleasant” or “lovely.” In the Septuagint, chapter 14 begins at this verse.
- l (14:24) Hebrew qadesh, “consecrated one,” probably a male prostitute associated with a shrine. The Septuagint reads “a conspiracy.”
- m (14:26) The Septuagint adds “and the golden spears that David took from the hand of the sons of Hadadezer king of Zobah and brought to Jerusalem” (compare 2 Samuel 8:7).
- n (14:27) Hebrew “the runners.”
- o (14:31) So the Hebrew here; 2 Chronicles 12:16 reads Abijah. Abijam may mean “my father is Yam” (“sea”), or it may be a variant form of Abijah. The Septuagint reads Abiu.

Chapter 15

1 In the eighteenth year of King Jeroboam son of Nebat, Abijam
became king over Judah. 2 He reigned three years in Jerusalem. His
mother’s name was Maacah,[a] daughter of Abishalom.[b] 3 He walked
in all the sins that his father had committed before him, and his
heart was not wholly true to Yahweh his God, as the heart of David
his forefather had been. 4 Even so, for David’s sake Yahweh his God
gave him a lamp in Jerusalem by raising up a son to follow him and
by keeping Jerusalem secure, 5 because David had done what was
right in Yahweh’s eyes and had not turned aside from anything he
commanded him all the days of his life, except in the matter of Uriah
the Hittite.[c] 6 There was war between Rehoboam[d] and Jeroboam all
the days of his life. 7 The rest of the acts of Abijam and all that he
did, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of
Judah? There was war between Abijam and Jeroboam. 8 Abijam slept
with his fathers, and they buried him in the city of David. And Asa[e]
his son reigned in his place.[f]
9 In the twentieth year of Jeroboam king of Israel,[g] Asa began to
reign over Judah, 10 Forty-one years he reigned in Jerusalem. His
grandmother[h] was named Maacah, the daughter of Abishalom. 11 Asa
did what was right in Yahweh’s eyes, as David his forefather had
done. 12 He drove the male shrine prostitutes out of the land and
removed all the idols[i] that his fathers had made. 13 He even removed
his grandmother Maacah from her position as queen mother, because
she had made a repulsive image[j] of Asherah. Asa cut the image down

and burned it in the Kidron Valley.[k] 14 But the high places were not
taken away. Nevertheless, Asa's heart was wholly true to Yahweh
all his days. 15 He brought into the house of Yahweh the holy things
his father had dedicated and his own dedicated gifts: silver, gold, and
vessels.
16 There was war between Asa and Baasha[l] king of Israel all their days.
17 Baasha king of Israel went up against Judah and fortified Ramah,[m]
to keep anyone from going out or coming in to Asa king of Judah.
18 Then Asa took all the silver and gold left in the treasure stores of
Yahweh's house and of the king's house and gave it into the hands of
his servants. King Asa sent them to Damascus, to the king of Aram,
Ben-hadad[n] son of Tabrimmon, son of Hezion, with this message: 19
"Let us make a treaty, you and I, like the one between my father and
yours. Here I have sent you a present of silver and gold. Go, break
your treaty with Baasha king of Israel, so that he will withdraw from
me." 20 Ben-hadad listened to King Asa and sent his army commanders
against Israel's towns; he conquered Ijon, Dan, Abel-beth-maacah,
and all Chinneroth,[o] along with all of Naphtali's territory. 21 When
Baasha heard of it, he stopped building Ramah and stayed in Tirzah.
22 Then King Asa gave an order to everyone in Judah, with no excep-
tions. They took away the stones and timber from Ramah that Baasha
had been using for building, and with them King Asa built up Geba[p] of
Benjamin and Mizpah.[q] 23 As for the rest of Asa's deeds, all his power,
everything he did, and the towns he built, are they not recorded in the
Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah? In his old age, however,
his feet became diseased. 24 Asa slept with his fathers and was buried
with his fathers in the city of David his father. And Jehoshaphat[r] his
son reigned in his place.
25 Nadab son of Jeroboam began to reign over Israel in the second
year of Asa king of Judah, and he reigned over Israel two years. 26 He
did what was evil in Yahweh's sight and walked in the way of his
father and in his sin, which he caused Israel to commit. 27 Baasha son
of Ahijah of the house of Issachar made a conspiracy against him.
Baasha killed him at Gibbethon,[s] a Philistine town, when Nadab and
all Israel were laying siege to Gibbethon. 28 So Baasha killed him in the

third year of Asa king of Judah and reigned in his place. [29] As soon as he became king, he struck down Jeroboam's whole house. He left no living person in Jeroboam's family but destroyed them all, in keeping with the word of Yahweh spoken through his servant Ahijah the Shilonite, [30] on account of the sins Jeroboam committed and caused Israel to commit, and the way he angered Yahweh, the God of Israel. [31] The rest of the acts of Nadab and all that he did, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel? [32] There was war between Asa and Baasha king of Israel all their days.[t]

[33] Baasha son of Ahijah became king over all Israel at Tirzah in the third year of Asa king of Judah, and he reigned twenty-four years. [34] He did what was evil in Yahweh's sight and walked in the way of Jeroboam and in his sin, which he caused Israel to commit.

Notes

- a (15:2) Maacah means "oppression" or perhaps "dull." 2 Chronicles 13:2 calls Abijah's mother Micaiah daughter of Uriel of Gibeah.
- b (15:2) Abishalom ("my father is peace") is a form of Absalom (2 Chronicles 11:20–21).
- c (15:5) The Septuagint lacks "except in the matter of Uriah the Hittite."
- d (15:6) So the Hebrew. Many interpreters think "Abijam" is meant (compare verse 7). The Septuagint lacks verse 6.
- e (15:8) Asa may mean "healer."
- f (15:8) The Septuagint adds "in the twenty-fourth year of Jeroboam."
- g (15:9) The Septuagint reads "In the twenty-fourth year of Jeroboam." The regnal numbers in Kings are given as they stand in the Hebrew.
- h (15:10) Hebrew "His mother's," here in the sense of grandmother (compare verse 2). The Septuagint calls her Ana.
- i (15:12) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous word for idols, perhaps "dung pellets."
- j (15:13) Hebrew miphletseth, "a thing to shudder at." The exact meaning is uncertain.
- k (15:13) Kidron perhaps means "dark" or "turbid." The valley lies between Jerusalem and the Mount of Olives.
- l (15:16) Baasha's name is of uncertain meaning.
- m (15:17) Ramah means "height." It lay about 5 miles (8 kilometers) north of Jerusalem.
- n (15:18) Ben-hadad means "son of Hadad," the Aramean storm god.
- o (15:20) Chinneroth is the region of the Sea of Galilee (Kinnereth, perhaps "lyre-shaped").
- p (15:22) Geba means "hill."

- q (15:22) Mizpah means “watchtower” or “lookout.”
- r (15:24) Jehoshaphat means “Yahweh has judged.”
- s (15:27) Gibbethon means “height” or “mound.”
- t (15:32) The Septuagint lacks verse 32, which repeats verse 16.

Chapter 16

1 The word of Yahweh came to Jehu[a] son of Hanani against Baasha:
2 “Since I lifted you up out of the dust and made you ruler over my
people Israel, and you have walked in the way of Jeroboam and have
caused my people Israel to sin, provoking me to anger with their sins,
3 I am about to sweep away Baasha and his house, and I will make
your house like the house of Jeroboam son of Nebat. 4 Dogs will eat
any of Baasha’s family who die in the city, and birds of the sky will
eat any who die in the country.”
5 The rest of the acts of Baasha, what he did and his might, are they
not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel? 6
Baasha slept with his fathers and was buried in Tirzah. And Elah[b] his
son reigned in his place. 7 Moreover, through the prophet Jehu son of
Hanani the word of Yahweh came against Baasha and his house, both
because of all the evil he did in Yahweh’s sight, provoking him to
anger with the work of his hands, in being like the house of Jeroboam,
and also because he struck it down.[c]
8 In the twenty-sixth year of Asa king of Judah, Elah son of Baasha
began to reign over Israel at Tirzah, and he reigned two years.[d] 9
Now Zimri,[e] his servant, who commanded half of his chariot force,
formed a plot against him. While Elah was in Tirzah, drinking until
drunk at the home of Arza, the palace steward in Tirzah, 10 Zimri
came in and struck him down and killed him, in the twenty-seventh
year of Asa king of Judah, and reigned in his place. 11 As soon as he
was king and sitting on the throne, he struck down Baasha’s whole
house. He did not leave a single male, whether relative or friend. 12
So Zimri destroyed all the house of Baasha, according to the word
of Yahweh that he spoke against Baasha through Jehu the prophet, 13
because of all the sins of Baasha and the sins of Elah his son, which
they committed and which they caused Israel to commit, provoking
Yahweh, the God of Israel, to anger with their worthless idols.[f] 14 The

rest of the acts of Elah and all that he did, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel?
15 In the twenty-seventh year of Asa king of Judah, Zimri reigned seven days at Tirzah. The army was encamped against Gibbethon, which belonged to the Philistines, 16 and the troops in the camp got word: "Zimri has plotted against the king and struck him down." So that day in the camp all Israel made Omri,[g] the commander of the army, king over Israel. 17 Omri went up from Gibbethon, and all Israel with him, and they besieged Tirzah. 18 When Zimri saw that the city was taken, he went into the citadel of the king's house and burned the king's house over himself with fire, and so he died, 19 because of the sins he had committed, doing what was evil in Yahweh's sight, walking in the way of Jeroboam and in the sin he committed, causing Israel to sin. 20 The rest of the acts of Zimri, and the conspiracy he carried out, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel?
21 Then the people of Israel split into two groups. Half the people followed Tibni son of Ginath and wanted to make him king, and the other half followed Omri. 22 But the people who followed Omri overpowered those who followed Tibni son of Ginath. Tibni died,[h] and Omri became king.
23 In the thirty-first year of Asa king of Judah, Omri began to reign over Israel, and he reigned twelve years; six years he reigned in Tirzah. 24 He purchased the hill of Samaria from Shemer with about 150 pounds of silver,[i] and built a city on the hill. He called the city Samaria,[j] after Shemer, who had owned the hill.
25 Omri did what was evil in Yahweh's sight, and he did more evil than all who were before him. 26 He walked in all the way of Jeroboam son of Nebat and in his sins, which he caused Israel to commit, provoking Yahweh, the God of Israel, to anger with their worthless idols. 27 As for the rest of Omri's deeds and the power he showed, are they not recorded in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel? 28 Omri slept with his fathers and was buried in Samaria. And Ahab[k] his son reigned in his place.[l]

29 In the thirty-eighth year of King Asa of Judah, Ahab son of Omri
became king over Israel, and he ruled over Israel from Samaria for
twenty-two years.[m] 30 And Ahab son of Omri did evil in Yahweh's
sight, more than all who were before him. 31 Not content with walking
in the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, he took Jezebel[n] as wife,
the daughter of Ethbaal,[o] the Sidonian king, and went to serve and
worship Baal.[p] 32 He set up an altar for Baal in the house of Baal, which
he built in Samaria. 33 Ahab also made an Asherah pole. Ahab did more
to provoke Yahweh, the God of Israel, to anger than all the kings of
Israel who were before him.
34 In his time Hiel[q] of Bethel rebuilt Jericho. It cost him his firstborn
Abiram when he laid its foundation, and his youngest son Segub
when he set up its gates, as Yahweh had said through Joshua son
of Nun.[r]

Notes

- a (16:1) Jehu means "Yahweh is he." Hanani means "gracious."
- b (16:6) Elah means "terebinth" or "oak."
- c (16:7) That is, because Baasha destroyed the house of Jeroboam (15:29).
- d (16:8) The Septuagint lacks the regnal synchronism in this verse, as in verses 10 and 15.
- e (16:9) Zimri may mean "my protection" or "my praise."
- f (16:13) Hebrew hebel, "breath, vapor," often used of idols as empty and futile.
- g (16:16) Omri's name is of uncertain meaning. Assyrian records later call Israel "the house of Omri."
- h (16:22) The Septuagint adds "and Joram his brother at that time."
- i (16:24) Hebrew "two talents of silver," about 68 kilograms. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- j (16:24) Hebrew Shomron, related to Shemer and perhaps meaning "watch hill." The Septuagint has Semeron.
- k (16:28) Ahab means "father's brother."
- l (16:28) The Septuagint adds here (16:28a–h) an account of the reign of Jehoshaphat of Judah, parallel to 22:41–50, dating his accession to the eleventh year of Omri.
- m (16:29) The Septuagint reads "In the second year of Jehoshaphat king of Judah." The regnal synchronisms are translated as they stand in the Hebrew.
- n (16:31) Jezebel may mean "Where is the prince?", a cry from the worship of Baal; the Hebrew vowels may have been altered to suggest zebel, "dung."
- o (16:31) Ethbaal means "with Baal" or "Baal exists."
- p (16:31) Baal means "lord" or "master," the title of the Canaanite storm god.

- q (16:34) Hiel means “God lives” or “brother of God.”
- r (16:34) See Joshua 6:26.

Chapter 17

1 Now Elijah[a] the Tishbite, of the settlers of Gilead,[b] said to Ahab, “As
Yahweh, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand, there will be
neither dew nor rain in these years except by my word.”
2 Then the word of Yahweh came to him: 3 “Leave this place, head
east, and hide by the Wadi Cherith,[c] facing the Jordan. 4 You will
drink from the brook, and I have commanded the ravens to feed you
there.” 5 So he went and did according to the word of Yahweh. He
went and stayed by the Wadi Cherith, east of the Jordan. 6 The ravens
brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in
the evening,[d] and he drank from the brook. 7 After a while the brook
dried up, because there had been no rain in the land.
8 Then the word of Yahweh came to him: 9 “Get up, go to Zarephath,[e]
which belongs to Sidon, and stay there. I have commanded a widow
there to provide for you.” 10 So he got up and went to Zarephath. At the
town gate he saw a widow gathering sticks. He called to her, “Please
bring me a little water in a cup so that I can drink.” 11 As she was going
to get it, he called to her and said, “Please bring me a bit of bread
in your hand.” 12 But she said, “As Yahweh your God lives, I have no
bread, just a fistful of flour in the jar and a little oil in the jug. Look, I
am picking up two sticks to go in and make it ready for my son and
myself, so we can eat it and then die.” 13 Elijah told her, “Do not be
afraid. Go and do as you have said. But first bake a little bread cake
for me from it and bring it to me; then prepare some for yourself and
your son. 14 For Yahweh, the God of Israel, says this: ‘The flour in the
jar shall not run out, nor the oil in the jug fail, until the day Yahweh
sends rain on the face of the ground.’ ” 15 She went and did what Elijah
told her, and there was food for her, for him, and for her household
many days. 16 The flour in the jar did not run out, nor did the oil in
the jug fail, according to the word of Yahweh that he spoke through
Elijah.

17 After these things the son of the woman, the mistress of the house,
became ill. His illness grew so severe that no breath was left in him.
18 She said to Elijah, "What have I to do with you, man of God?[f] Have
you come to me to bring my sin to remembrance and to kill my son?"
19 "Give me your son," he said. He took him from her lap, brought him
to the upper room where he was staying, and laid him on his own
bed. 20 Then he cried out to Yahweh, "Yahweh my God, have you also
brought calamity on the widow with whom I am staying, by killing
her son?" 21 Then he stretched himself out on the child three times
and cried out to Yahweh, "Yahweh my God, please let this child's life[g]
come back into him." 22 Yahweh listened to the voice of Elijah, and the
child's life came back into him, and he revived. 23 Elijah picked up the
child and carried him down from the upper room into the house and
gave him to his mother. And Elijah said, "See, your son is alive." 24 The
woman said to Elijah, "Now I know that you are a man of God, and
that the word of Yahweh in your mouth is truth."

Notes

- a (17:1) Elijah means "my God is Yahweh" (Hebrew Eliyyahu).
- b (17:1) Hebrew mittoshabe gil'ad, "of the settlers of Gilead." The Septuagint reads "of Tishbe in Gilead," reading the same consonants as a place name. Gilead, the hill country east of the Jordan, may mean "rugged" or "heap of witness."
- c (17:3) Cherith perhaps means "cutting" or "ravine." A wadi is a streambed that is dry except in the rainy season.
- d (17:6) The Septuagint reads "bread in the morning and meat in the evening."
- e (17:9) Zarephath means "smelting place." It lay on the coast between Tyre and Sidon.
- f (17:18) Hebrew "What to me and to you?", an idiom of protest or distancing.
- g (17:21) Hebrew nephesh, "soul, life, breath."

Chapter 18

1 After many days the word of Yahweh came to Elijah, in the third
year: "Go, show yourself to Ahab, and I will send rain on the face of
the ground." 2 So Elijah went to show himself to Ahab. The famine was
severe in Samaria. 3 Ahab called Obadiah,[a] who was over the house-
hold. (Obadiah feared Yahweh greatly. 4 When Jezebel was killing off
the prophets of Yahweh, Obadiah took a hundred prophets and hid
them, fifty to a cave, and supplied them with bread and water.) 5 Ahab

told Obadiah, “Go through the land to every spring and every valley
stream. We may find grass to keep the horses and mules alive, so that
we will not have to destroy any of the animals.” 6 So they divided the
land between them to pass through it. Ahab went one way by himself,
and Obadiah went another way by himself.
7 As Obadiah was on the way, there was Elijah coming to meet him.
Obadiah recognized him, fell on his face, and said, “Is it you, my lord
Elijah?” 8 He answered him, “It is I. Go, tell your lord, ‘Elijah is here.’
” 9 Obadiah said, “What sin have I committed, that you would hand
your servant over to Ahab to put me to death? 10 As surely as Yahweh
your God lives, there is no nation or kingdom where my lord has
not sent people to search for you. Whenever they said, ‘He is not
here,’ he made that kingdom or nation take an oath that they had not
found you. 11 And now you say, ‘Go, tell your lord, “Elijah is here.” ’ 12
As soon as I leave you, the Spirit of Yahweh will carry you I do not
know where. Then when I come and tell Ahab and he cannot find
you, he will kill me, though I your servant have feared Yahweh from
my youth. 13 Has my lord not been told what I did when Jezebel killed
the prophets of Yahweh, how I hid a hundred of Yahweh’s prophets,
fifty to a cave, and supplied them with bread and water? 14 And now
you tell me, ‘Go and tell your lord, “Elijah is here”’? He will kill me!”
15 Elijah said, “As Yahweh of hosts lives, before whom I stand, I will
certainly show myself to him today.” 16 So Obadiah went to meet Ahab
and told him, and Ahab went to meet Elijah.
17 When Ahab saw Elijah, Ahab said to him, “Is that you, you troubler
of Israel?” 18 He answered, “It is not I who have brought trouble
on Israel. You and your father’s family have done it, by forsaking
what Yahweh commanded and going after the Baals. 19 Now then,
summon all Israel to meet me at Mount Carmel,[b] along with Baal’s
four hundred fifty prophets and Asherah’s four hundred prophets,
the ones Jezebel feeds at her table.”
20 So Ahab sent word among all the Israelites and gathered the
prophets together at Mount Carmel. 21 Elijah approached all the
people and said, “How long will you go back and forth between two
opinions?[c] If Yahweh is God, follow him; if Baal, follow him.” The

people said nothing in reply. 22 Then Elijah said to the people, “I, I
alone, am left as a prophet of Yahweh, but Baal’s prophets are four
hundred and fifty men.[d] 23 Have them give us two bulls. They may
pick one bull, cut it up, and set it on the wood without lighting any
fire. I will make the second bull ready, set it on the wood, and light
no fire either. 24 Then you call on the name of your god, and I will call
on the name of Yahweh. The God who answers by fire, he is God.”
And all the people answered, “Well spoken.”[e] 25 Then Elijah said to the
prophets of Baal, “Choose one bull for yourselves and prepare it first,
for you are many. Call on the name of your god, but put no fire to
it.” 26 So they took the bull that was given them and made it ready,
and from morning to noon they kept calling on Baal’s name: “Baal,
answer us!” But not a sound came, and no one answered. And they
limped about the altar they had made. 27 At noon Elijah mocked them,
saying, “Call out louder, for he is a god! Perhaps he is deep in thought,
or he has gone aside,[f] or he is on a journey. Perhaps he is asleep and
must be awakened.” 28 So they cried louder and, as was their custom,
cut themselves with swords and lances until the blood poured over
them. 29 When midday had passed, they raved on[g] until the time of
the offering of the evening grain offering,[h] yet there was no sound,
no answer, no one listening.
30 Then Elijah said to all the people, “Come near to me.” All the people
came near to him, and he repaired the altar of Yahweh that had been
torn down. 31 Elijah took twelve stones, one for each of the tribes of
Jacob’s sons, to whom Yahweh’s word had come: “Israel will be your
name.” 32 With the stones he built an altar in the name of Yahweh. He
made a trench around the altar large enough to hold about 4 gallons
of seed.[i] 33 He arranged the wood, cut the bull in pieces, and laid it
on the wood. Then he said, “Fill four jars with water and pour it on
the burnt offering and on the wood.” 34 He said, “Again,” and they did
it again. He said, “A third time,” and they did it a third time. 35 The
water ran around the altar, and he filled the trench also with water.
36 At the time of the offering of the evening grain offering, Elijah the
prophet came near and said, “Yahweh, God of Abraham, Isaac, and
Israel, let it be known today that you are God in Israel, and that I

am your servant, and that I have done all these things at your word.
37 Answer me, Yahweh, answer me, so that this people may know
that you, Yahweh, are God, and that you have turned their hearts
back again." 38 Then the fire of Yahweh fell and consumed the burnt
offering, the wood, the stones, and the dust, and licked up the water
that was in the trench. 39 When all the people saw it, they fell on their
faces and said, "Yahweh, he is God! Yahweh, he is God!" 40 Elijah said
to them, "Seize the prophets of Baal. Do not let one of them escape."
They seized them, and Elijah brought them down to the Wadi Kishon[j]
and slaughtered them there.
41 Then Elijah said to Ahab, "Go up, eat and drink, for there is the
sound of a roaring rain." 42 So Ahab went up to eat and drink. Elijah
went up to the top of Carmel, bowed himself down on the ground, and
put his face between his knees. 43 He said to his servant, "Go up now
and look toward the sea." He went up and looked and said, "There is
nothing." Seven times Elijah said, "Go again." 44 On the seventh time
the servant said, "I see a small cloud, as small as a man's hand, rising
out of the sea." Elijah said, "Go up and tell Ahab, 'Get your chariot
ready and go down, so that the rain will not hold you back.' " 45 In a
little while the sky grew black with clouds and wind, and a downpour
came. Ahab got in his chariot and headed for Jezreel.[k] 46 But the hand
of Yahweh was on Elijah. He tucked up his robe[l] and ran ahead of
Ahab all the way to the entrance of Jezreel.

Notes

- a (18:3) Obadiah means "servant of Yahweh." The Septuagint calls him Abdiu.
- b (18:19) Carmel means "garden land" or "orchard." The mountain ridge runs from the Mediterranean coast near modern Haifa toward the southeast.
- c (18:21) Hebrew "between the two branches" or "crutches." The Septuagint reads "halt on both feet."
- d (18:22) The Septuagint adds "and the prophets of the Asherah, four hundred."
- e (18:24) Hebrew "The word is good."
- f (18:27) Probably a euphemism for relieving himself.
- g (18:29) Hebrew "they prophesied," here of frenzied ecstatic behavior.
- h (18:29) Hebrew "until the going up of the minchah." The evening grain offering was made in the late afternoon, about 3 p.m. Here the Septuagint adds "and Elijah spoke to the prophets of the abominations, saying, 'Stand aside now, and I will offer my burnt offering.' "

- i (18:32) Hebrew "as great as a house of two seahs of seed," either a trench holding two seahs (about 15 liters) of seed, or one enclosing an area that two seahs of seed would sow. A seah was about 7 quarts (about 7.3 liters).
- j (18:40) Kishon may mean "winding." It drains the Jezreel Valley to the sea north of Carmel.
- k (18:45) Jezreel means "God sows."
- l (18:46) Hebrew "he girded his loins."

Chapter 19

1 Ahab told Jezebel all that Elijah had done, including how he had killed all the prophets with the sword. 2 Then Jezebel sent a messenger to Elijah, saying,[a] "May the gods deal with me, and worse, if by this hour tomorrow I have not done to your life what was done to each of theirs." 3 He was afraid,[b] and he got up and fled for his life. He came to Beersheba,[c] which belongs to Judah, and left his servant there. 4 But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness. He came and sat down under a broom bush[d] and asked that he might die. "It is enough," he said. "Now, Yahweh, take my life, for I am no better than my ancestors." 5 He lay down and fell asleep under the broom bush. Suddenly an angel touched him and said to him, "Get up and eat." 6 He looked, and near his head lay a loaf baked on heated stones, and a jar of water. After eating and drinking, he lay down once more. 7 The angel of Yahweh returned a second time, touched him, and said, "Get up and eat, or the journey will be too much for you." 8 He got up, ate and drank, and in the strength of that food he walked forty days and forty nights to Horeb,[e] the mountain of God.

9 There he came to a cave and spent the night. And the word of Yahweh came to him, and he said to him, "What are you doing here, Elijah?" 10 He answered, "I have been very zealous for Yahweh, the God of hosts. The Israelites have forsaken your covenant; they have torn down your altars and put your prophets to death by the sword. I am the only one left, and now they want my life too." 11 He said, "Go out and stand on the mountain before Yahweh." And look, Yahweh was passing by. A great and mighty wind was tearing the mountains apart and shattering the rocks before Yahweh, but Yahweh was not in the wind. After the wind came an earthquake, but Yahweh was not in

the earthquake. 12 After the earthquake came a fire, but Yahweh was
not in the fire. And after the fire, the sound of a thin silence.[f] 13 When
Elijah heard it, he wrapped his face in his cloak, went out, and stood
at the cave's entrance. And a voice came to him: "What are you doing
here, Elijah?" 14 He answered, "I have been very zealous for Yahweh,
the God of hosts. The Israelites have forsaken your covenant; they
have torn down your altars and put your prophets to death by the
sword. I am the only one left, and now they want my life too." 15
Yahweh said to him, "Go back the way you came, to the wilderness of
Damascus. When you get there, anoint Hazael[g] to be king of Aram. 16
Anoint also Jehu[h] the son of Nimshi to be king of Israel, and anoint
Elisha[i] the son of Shaphat, from Abel-meholah,[j] to succeed you as
prophet. 17 Anyone who gets away from Hazael's sword Jehu will put
to death, and anyone who gets away from Jehu's sword Elisha will put
to death. 18 Yet I will leave seven thousand in Israel, all the knees that
have not bowed to Baal and every mouth that has not kissed him."
19 So he went from there and found Elisha son of Shaphat. He was
plowing; twelve pairs of oxen went before him, and he drove the
last. Elijah crossed over to him and flung his cloak on him. 20 Elisha
abandoned the oxen and hurried after Elijah. "Let me kiss my father
and my mother," he said, "and then I will follow you." "Go back,"
Elijah replied. "What have I done to you?"[k] 21 Elisha turned back
from following him, took the yoke of oxen, and slaughtered them.
He boiled their meat using the oxen's gear for fuel and gave it to the
people, and they ate. Then he got up, followed Elijah, and served him.

Notes

- a (19:2) The Septuagint begins Jezebel's message, "If you are Elijah and I am Jezebel, …"
- b (19:3) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses. The Masoretic text vocalizes the consonants as "He saw."
- c (19:3) Beersheba means "well of seven" or "well of the oath."
- d (19:4) Or "juniper," as in older translations. The plant is the white broom (retama).
- e (19:8) Horeb means "dryness" or "desolation"; it is another name for Mount Sinai.
- f (19:12) Or "a gentle whisper," "a still small voice." The Septuagint reads "the sound of a gentle breeze."
- g (19:15) Hazael means "God sees."

- h (19:16) Jehu means "Yahweh is he."
- i (19:16) Elisha means "God saves."
- j (19:16) Abel-meholah means "meadow of dancing."
- k (19:20) Or "Go back, for what have I done to you?" The sense is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "Return, for I have done a work for you."

Chapter 20

1 King Ben-hadad[a] of Aram[b] gathered his entire army. Thirty-two
kings joined him with their horses and chariots, and he went up,
besieged Samaria, and fought against it. 2 He sent messengers into the
city to Ahab king of Israel with this word: "Thus says Ben-hadad: 3
'Your silver and gold belong to me, and the best of your wives and
sons belong to me as well.' " 4 The king of Israel replied, "It is as you
have said, my lord the king. I and everything I own are yours." 5 The
messengers came back and said, "This is what Ben-hadad says: 'I sent
you word that you must hand over to me your silver and your gold,
your wives and your children. 6 But about this time tomorrow I will
send my servants to you, and they will search your house and your
servants' houses. Whatever pleases your eyes[c] they will lay hands on
and carry away.' "
7 Then the king of Israel summoned all the elders of the land and
said, "Take note and see how this man is looking for trouble. He
demanded my wives and my sons, my silver and my gold, and I held
nothing back from him." 8 All the elders and all the people said to
him, "Do not listen, and do not consent." 9 So he told Ben-hadad's
messengers, "Say to my lord the king, 'Everything you first asked of
your servant I will do, but this demand I am unable to meet.' " The
messengers left and took the answer back. 10 Ben-hadad sent word to
him: "May the gods do so to me and more also, if the dust of Samaria
is enough to give a handful to each of the people who follow me." 11
The king of Israel answered, "Tell him, 'The one who straps on his
armor should not boast like the one who takes it off.' " 12 Ben-hadad
received this message while he and the kings were drinking in the
temporary shelters.[d] He told his men, "Get into position!" and they
took up positions against the city.

13 Then a prophet approached Ahab king of Israel and said, “This is
what Yahweh says: ‘Do you see all this great horde? I am giving it
into your hand today, and you will know that I am Yahweh.’ ” 14 Ahab
asked, “By whom?” He said, “This is what Yahweh says: ‘By the young
men who serve the district governors.’ ” Then he asked, “Who will
begin the battle?” He answered, “You.” 15 So Ahab counted the young
men of the district governors; there were 232 of them. After them he
counted the whole fighting force of Israel, seven thousand. 16 They set
out at noon. Ben-hadad, meanwhile, was getting drunk in the booths
together with the thirty-two kings who had come to help him. 17 The
young men of the district governors led the way out. Ben-hadad had
sent men out, and word came back to him: “Some men are coming
out of Samaria.” 18 He said, “If they have come out for peace, take them
alive. If they have come out for war, take them alive.” 19 But these went
out from the city, the young men of the district governors and the
army behind them, 20 and each one struck down his man. Aram fled,
and Israel pursued them, but Ben-hadad king of Aram escaped on a
horse with some horsemen. 21 The king of Israel went out and struck
the horses and chariots, and inflicted a great defeat on Aram.
22 Then the prophet came to the king of Israel and said to him, “Go,
strengthen yourself, and consider well what you must do, because
when the year turns[e] Aram’s king will march on you again.” 23 The
officials of the king of Aram told him, “Their gods are gods of the
hills, and that is why they overpowered us. But if we fight them on
level ground, we will certainly overpower them. 24 And do this: take
every one of the kings out of his command, and appoint governors
instead. 25 Then muster an army like the army you lost, horse for horse
and chariot for chariot. Let us fight them on the plain, and surely we
will be stronger than they.” He listened to their advice and did so.
26 In the spring Ben-hadad mustered Aram and went up to Aphek[f] to
fight against Israel. 27 The Israelites were mustered and provisioned
and went out to meet them. The Israelites camped opposite them like
two little flocks of goats, while Aram filled the countryside. 28 The
man of God approached the king of Israel and said, “This is what
Yahweh says: ‘Because the Arameans have said, “Yahweh is a god of

the hills and not of the valleys," I will hand this whole huge army over to you, and you will know that I am Yahweh.' " [29] They camped facing one another for seven days. On the seventh day the battle was joined, and the Israelites struck down one hundred thousand Aramean foot soldiers in one day. [30] The rest fled to Aphek, into the city, and the wall collapsed on twenty-seven thousand of the men who remained. Ben-hadad also fled and came into the city, into an inner room.

[31] His servants said to him, "Look, we have heard that the kings of Israel's house keep faith and show mercy. Let us wrap sackcloth around our waists, put ropes on our heads, and go out to Israel's king. He may let you live." [32] They wrapped sackcloth around their waists, put ropes on their heads, and came to the king of Israel. "Your servant Ben-hadad says, 'Please let me live,' " they said. He replied, "Is he still alive? He is my brother." [33] The men took that as a good sign and quickly seized on his word:[g] "Yes, your brother Ben-hadad!" "Go and get him," he said. When Ben-hadad came out, Ahab had him get up into his chariot. [34] Ben-hadad told him, "I will return the towns my father took from your father, and you may set up bazaars[h] in Damascus for yourself, as my father did in Samaria." Ahab said,[i] "On those terms I will let you go." So he made a treaty with him and sent him away.

[35] By the word of Yahweh a certain man of the sons of the prophets[j] said to his companion, "Strike me." But the man refused to strike him. [36] Then he said to him, "Because you have not obeyed the voice of Yahweh, as soon as you leave me a lion will kill you." And when he left him, a lion found him and killed him. [37] Then he found another man and said, "Strike me." The man struck him and wounded him. [38] The prophet went and stood by the road to wait for the king, disguised with a bandage over his eyes. [39] As the king passed by, he cried out to the king, "Your servant had gone out into the middle of the fighting. A man stepped aside and brought someone to me and said, 'Guard this man. If he goes missing, your life will be forfeit for his life, or else you will pay about 75 pounds of silver.'[k] [40] While your servant was busy with one thing and another, he vanished." "That is your sentence," the king of Israel said to him. "You have decided it yourself." [41] Then he

quickly removed the bandage from his eyes, and the king of Israel recognized him as one of the prophets. 42 He said to the king, "This is what Yahweh says: 'Because you let slip from your hand the man I had devoted to destruction, your life shall go for his life, and your people for his people.' " 43 The king of Israel went home to Samaria, sullen and angry.

Notes

- a (20:1) The Septuagint places this chapter after the story of Naboth's vineyard, numbering it chapter 21; its chapter 20 is the Hebrew and English chapter 21. Benhadad means "son of Hadad," the Aramean storm god. The Septuagint renders it "the son of Ader."
- b (20:1) Aram is the land of the Arameans, centered on Damascus; older translations call it Syria, following the Septuagint.
- c (20:6) Hebrew "the desire of your eyes." The Septuagint has "the desirable things of their eyes."
- d (20:12) Hebrew sukkot, temporary shelters of a field camp. The Septuagint reads the place name Succoth at verse 16.
- e (20:22) Hebrew "at the return of the year," the season when kings went to war; likewise in verse 26.
- f (20:26) Aphek means "fortress." Several towns bore the name; this one was probably east of the Sea of Galilee.
- g (20:33) The Hebrew of this clause is uncertain.
- h (20:34) Hebrew "streets," probably market quarters for merchants.
- i (20:34) Hebrew lacks "Ahab said."
- j (20:35) That is, a member of a prophetic guild.
- k (20:39) Hebrew "a talent of silver." A talent weighed about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).

Chapter 21

1 After these things there was the matter of a vineyard belonging to Naboth[a] the Jezreelite. It was in Jezreel, beside the palace of Ahab king of Samaria.[b] 2 Ahab said to Naboth, "Give me your vineyard for a vegetable garden, since it is next to my palace. In place of it I will give you a better vineyard; or, if you would rather, I will pay you its price in silver." 3 But Naboth said to Ahab, "Yahweh forbid that I should give you the inheritance of my ancestors." 4 Ahab went home sullen and angry about the reply Naboth the Jezreelite had given him: "I will not

hand over my ancestral inheritance to you." Turning his face away, he lay down on his bed and refused food.
5 His wife Jezebel came to him and asked, "Why are you so dispirited
that you will not eat?" 6 He told her, "Because I spoke to Naboth the
Jezreelite and said to him, 'Let me buy your vineyard for silver, or I
will trade you some other vineyard for it, if you would rather.' But
he answered, 'I will not give you my vineyard.' " 7 His wife Jezebel
said to him, "Are you not the one who rules Israel now? Get up, eat
something, and cheer up. I will get you the vineyard of Naboth the
Jezreelite."
8 So she wrote letters in Ahab's name, sealed them with his seal, and
sent them to the elders and nobles of Naboth's town, his neighbors
there. 9 This is what the letters said: "Call for a fast and give Naboth
a seat of honor before the people. 10 Put two worthless men[c] across
from him, and let them bear witness against him: 'You have cursed[d]
God and the king.' Then lead him out and stone him until he dies." 11
The elders and nobles of Naboth's town, who lived there with him,
carried out Jezebel's instructions exactly as her letters had directed.
12 They called for a fast and gave Naboth a seat of honor before the
people. 13 Then the two worthless men came and took their seats
across from him and bore witness against Naboth before the people:
"Naboth cursed God and the king." So they took him outside the town
and stoned him with stones, and he died. 14 Then they sent a message
to Jezebel: "Naboth was stoned and has died."
15 As soon as Jezebel heard that Naboth had been stoned and was
dead, she said to Ahab, "Get up and take possession of the vineyard
of Naboth the Jezreelite, which he would not sell you. Naboth is
not living anymore; he is dead." 16 When Ahab heard that Naboth
was dead, Ahab got up[e] to go down to the vineyard of Naboth the
Jezreelite and take possession of it.
17 Then the word of Yahweh came to Elijah the Tishbite: 18 "Get up
and go down to meet Ahab king of Israel, who is in Samaria. He is
in Naboth's vineyard, where he has gone to take possession of it. 19
Tell him, 'This is what Yahweh says: Have you murdered and also
taken possession?' And tell him, 'This is what Yahweh says: On the

very spot where dogs lapped Naboth's blood, dogs will lap up your own blood too.' "[f] 20 Ahab said to Elijah, "So you have found me, my enemy?" He answered, "I have found you, because you have sold yourself to do what is evil in the sight of Yahweh. 21 I am about to bring disaster on you. I will sweep you away and cut off from Ahab every male,[g] slave or free,[h] in Israel. 22 I will treat your house as I treated the houses of Jeroboam son of Nebat and Baasha son of Ahijah, because you have made me angry and have led Israel into sin. 23 And concerning Jezebel also Yahweh has spoken: 'The dogs will eat Jezebel by the rampart[i] of Jezreel.' 24 Whoever of Ahab's family dies within the city will be eaten by dogs, and whoever dies in the countryside will be eaten by the birds of the sky."

25 (No one ever sold himself to do evil in Yahweh's eyes as Ahab did, urged on by his wife Jezebel. 26 He acted most abominably in going after idols,[j] just as the Amorites had done, whom Yahweh drove out before the Israelites.) 27 When Ahab heard these words, he tore his clothes, put sackcloth on his body, and fasted. He lay in sackcloth and went about subdued.[k] 28 Then the word of Yahweh came to Elijah the Tishbite: 29 "Do you see how Ahab has bowed low before me? Since he has bowed low before me, I will hold back the disaster during his lifetime. It is in his son's time that I will bring ruin on his house."

Notes

- a (21:1) The Septuagint places this chapter before the account of the Aramean wars (English chapter 20), as its chapter 20. Naboth may mean "sprout" or "fruit."
- b (21:1) The Septuagint reads "near the threshing floor of Ahab king of Samaria" and lacks "in Jezreel."
- c (21:10) Hebrew "sons of Belial," that is, scoundrels; likewise in verse 13.
- d (21:10) Hebrew "blessed," a scribal euphemism for "cursed"; likewise in verse 13.
- e (21:16) The Septuagint adds that Ahab tore his clothes and put on sackcloth, and only afterward got up and went down.
- f (21:19) The Septuagint reads "In every place where the swine and the dogs licked the blood of Naboth, there the dogs will lick your blood," and adds "and the prostitutes will bathe in your blood" (compare 22:38).
- g (21:21) Hebrew "every one who urinates against a wall."
- h (21:21) The meaning of the Hebrew pair ʿatsur weʿazub is uncertain: perhaps "bond or free," or "ruler or helper."

- i (21:23) Hebrew chel, “rampart” or “outer wall.” Compare 2 Kings 9:36, “the plot of ground of Jezreel.”
- j (21:26) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous term for idols, perhaps “dung pellets.”
- k (21:27) Hebrew “softly” or “quietly.” The Septuagint reads “weeping.”

Chapter 22

1 Three years went by with no war between Aram and Israel. 2 In
the third year, though, Judah’s king Jehoshaphat[a] came down to visit
the king of Israel. 3 The king of Israel said to his officials, “You know
that Ramoth-gilead[b] is ours, don’t you? Yet we sit still and do not
take it back from Aram’s king.” 4 He asked Jehoshaphat, “Will you
come with me to fight at Ramoth-gilead?” Jehoshaphat answered the
king of Israel, “You and I are one, my people and yours, my horses
and yours.”
5 But Jehoshaphat also said to the king of Israel, “First, please, inquire
for the word of Yahweh.” 6 So the king of Israel assembled the
prophets, around four hundred of them, and asked, “Should I march
against Ramoth-gilead, or should I refrain?” They said, “Go up, for
the Lord[c] will give it into the king’s hand.” 7 But Jehoshaphat said, “Is
there no other prophet of Yahweh here, of whom we may inquire?”
8 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, “There is still one man
through whom we could inquire of Yahweh, Micaiah[d] son of Imlah.
But I hate him, because he never prophesies good about me, only evil.”
Jehoshaphat said, “The king should not say so.” 9 So the king of Israel
called an officer and said, “Bring Micaiah son of Imlah at once.”
10 Now Israel’s king and Judah’s king Jehoshaphat sat on their thrones
in royal robes at the threshing floor by the entry to Samaria’s gate,
while all the prophets prophesied in front of them. 11 Zedekiah[e] son
of Chenaanah made himself horns of iron and said, “This is what
Yahweh says: ‘With these you will butt the Arameans till you have
finished them off.’ ” 12 All the other prophets were saying the same:
“Attack Ramoth-gilead and win! Yahweh will hand it over to the
king.”
13 The messenger sent to call Micaiah told him, “See here, the prophets
are all of one voice in speaking favorably to the king. Please make
your message agree with theirs and say something good.” 14 But

Micaiah said, “As Yahweh lives, whatever Yahweh says to me, that
is what I will speak.” 15 When he came to the king, the king said to
him, “Micaiah, shall we go to battle against Ramoth-gilead, or shall
we hold back?” He answered him, “Go up and triumph. Yahweh will
give it into the king’s hand.” 16 But the king said to him, “How often
must I put you under oath to say only what is true when you speak to
me in Yahweh’s name?” 17 Then he said, “I saw all Israel scattered on
the mountains, like sheep that have no shepherd. And Yahweh said,
‘These have no master. Let each of them go home in peace.’ ” 18 The
king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, “Did I not tell you that he would
prophesy nothing good about me, only evil?”
19 Micaiah said, “Therefore hear Yahweh’s word: I saw Yahweh sitting
on his throne, and all the army of heaven standing by him, on his right
and on his left. 20 Yahweh asked, ‘Who will lure Ahab into attacking
Ramoth-gilead and dying there?’ One suggested this, another that. 21
Then a spirit came forward and stood before Yahweh and said, ‘I will
entice him.’ 22 Yahweh asked him, ‘How?’ He said, ‘I will go out and
become a deceiving spirit in the mouths of all his prophets.’ Yahweh
said, ‘Entice him you shall, and you will succeed. Go out and do it.’ 23
So now, look, Yahweh has put a lying spirit in the mouth of all these
prophets of yours. Yahweh has decreed disaster for you.”
24 Zedekiah son of Chenaanah went up and slapped Micaiah on the
cheek. “How did the Spirit of Yahweh leave me to speak to you?” he
asked. 25 Micaiah said, “You will see on the day you go into an inner
room to hide.” 26 The king of Israel said, “Take Micaiah and return him
to Amon the governor of the city and to Joash the king’s son, 27 and
say, ‘This is what the king says: Put this fellow in prison and feed
him on short rations of bread and water[f] until I come back safely.’
” 28 Micaiah said, “If you ever return safely, Yahweh has not spoken
through me.” And he added, “Hear this, all you peoples!”[g]
29 So the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat king of Judah went up to
Ramoth-gilead. 30 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, “I will go
into the fight in disguise, while you keep your royal robes on.” So
Israel’s king disguised himself and entered the battle. 31 The king of
Aram had ordered his thirty-two chariot commanders, “Do not fight

anyone, small or great, except the king of Israel." 32 When the chariot
commanders saw Jehoshaphat, they said, "Surely that is the king of
Israel." So they turned to fight against him, and Jehoshaphat cried
out. 33 When the chariot commanders saw that it was not the king
of Israel, they turned back from pursuing him. 34 Someone drew his
bow at random[h] and struck the king of Israel in a gap between the
pieces of his armor. The king told his chariot driver, "Turn around
and take me out of the fighting,[i] for I am wounded." 35 The battle grew
fierce that day, and the king was propped up in his chariot facing
the Arameans. The blood from the wound ran into the floor of the
chariot, and at evening he died. 36 As the sun was going down, a shout
passed through the ranks: "Each man to his own town, each to his
own country!" 37 So the king died and was brought to Samaria, and
they buried the king in Samaria. 38 They washed the chariot by the
pool of Samaria, and the dogs licked up his blood, and the prostitutes
bathed there,[j] according to the word that Yahweh had spoken. 39 The
rest of the acts of Ahab and all that he did, the ivory house he built
and all the towns he built, are they not written in the Book of the
Annals of the Kings of Israel? 40 So Ahab slept with his ancestors, and
Ahaziah[k] his son reigned in his place.
41 Jehoshaphat son of Asa began to reign over Judah in the fourth year
of Ahab king of Israel. 42 Jehoshaphat was thirty-five years old when
he began to reign, and he reigned twenty-five years in Jerusalem. His
mother's name was Azubah[l] daughter of Shilhi. 43 He followed the
whole path of Asa his father without swerving from it, doing what
pleased Yahweh. Yet the high places were not removed; the people
still sacrificed and burned incense on the high places.[m] 44 Jehoshaphat
also made peace with the king of Israel. 45 The rest of the acts of Je-
hoshaphat, the might he showed, and how he waged war, are they not
written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 46 He purged
from the land the rest of the male cult prostitutes[n] who remained
from the days of his father Asa.[o] 47 There was no king in Edom; a
deputy served as king. 48 Jehoshaphat made ships of Tarshish[p] to sail
to Ophir for gold, but they never sailed, because they were wrecked
at Ezion-geber. 49 Then Ahaziah son of Ahab said to Jehoshaphat, "Let

my servants go with your servants in the ships," but Jehoshaphat was not willing. 50 Then Jehoshaphat slept with his ancestors and was buried beside them in the city of David his father, and Jehoram[q] his son reigned in his place.

51 Ahaziah son of Ahab began to reign over Israel in Samaria in the seventeenth year of Jehoshaphat king of Judah, and he reigned two years over Israel. 52 He did what was evil in the sight of Yahweh and walked in the way of his father and in the way of his mother and in the way of Jeroboam son of Nebat, who made Israel sin. 53 He served Baal and worshiped him and provoked Yahweh, the God of Israel, to anger, just as his father had done.

Notes

- a (22:2) Jehoshaphat means "Yahweh has judged."
- b (22:3) Ramoth-gilead means "heights of Gilead."
- c (22:6) Hebrew Adonai.
- d (22:8) Micaiah means "Who is like Yahweh?"
- e (22:11) Zedekiah means "Yahweh is righteousness."
- f (22:27) Hebrew "bread of affliction and water of affliction."
- g (22:28) These words are identical to the opening of Micah 1:2 and may be a later link between the two prophets named Micah/Micaiah. The Septuagint lacks them.
- h (22:34) Hebrew "in his innocence," that is, at random.
- i (22:34) Hebrew "the camp"; the Septuagint reads "the battle."
- j (22:38) Or "they washed the armor." The Septuagint reads "the swine and the dogs licked up the blood, and the prostitutes washed themselves in the blood."
- k (22:40) Ahaziah means "Yahweh has grasped."
- l (22:42) Azubah means "forsaken."
- m (22:43) The Hebrew text divides this verse into two (verses 43 and 44), so for the rest of the chapter the Hebrew numbering is one higher than the English.
- n (22:46) Hebrew qadesh. See the note at 14:24.
- o (22:46) The Septuagint lacks verses 46–49. Some of this material appears in its addition at 16:28a–h.
- p (22:48) Ships of Tarshish were large seagoing merchant ships. The Ketiv reads "ten ships."
- q (22:50) Jehoram means "Yahweh is exalted."

2 Kings

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 After the death of Ahab, Moab[a] rebelled against Israel.
2 Ahaziah had fallen through the latticework of his roof chamber in
Samaria and been hurt. He sent off messengers with orders: "Go,
inquire of Baal-zebub,[b] the god of Ekron,[c] whether I will recover from
this injury." 3 But the angel of Yahweh said to Elijah the Tishbite, "Get
up, go up to meet the messengers of the king of Samaria, and say
to them, 'Is it because there is no God in Israel that you are going
to inquire of Baal-zebub, the god of Ekron? 4 Therefore this is what
Yahweh says: You will not come down from the bed you have gone up
to. You will surely die.' " And Elijah went on his way. 5 The messengers
returned to the king, and he asked them, "Why have you come back?"
6 They told him, "A man came up to meet us and said to us, 'Go back
to the king who sent you and tell him, "This is what Yahweh says: Is
it because there is no God in Israel that you are sending to inquire
of Baal-zebub, the god of Ekron? Therefore you will not come down
from the bed you have gone up to. You will surely die." ' " 7 He asked
them, "What sort of man was he who came up to meet you and told
you these things?" 8 They answered him, "A hairy man,[d] with a leather
belt tied around his waist." He said, "It is Elijah the Tishbite."
9 Then the king sent a captain of fifty with his fifty men to him. He
went up to Elijah, who was sitting on top of a hill, and said to him,
"Man of God, the king says, 'Come down.' " 10 Elijah answered the
captain of fifty, "If I am a man of God, let fire come down from heaven
and consume you and your fifty." Then fire came down from heaven
and consumed him and his fifty. 11 Again the king sent to him another
captain of fifty with his fifty. He spoke up and said to him, "Man of
God, the king commands you to come down at once." 12 Elijah replied,
"If I am truly a man of God, may fire fall from the sky and burn up

you and your fifty men." And God's fire fell from the sky and burned up the captain and his fifty. 13 Once more the king sent out a third captain with fifty men. This third captain climbed the hill, knelt down in front of Elijah, and pleaded with him: "Man of God, please, may my life and the lives of these fifty servants of yours be valuable to you. 14 Fire has come down from heaven and consumed the first two captains of fifty with their fifties. But now let my life be precious in your sight." 15 Then the angel of Yahweh told Elijah, "Go down with him. Have no fear of him." So Elijah rose and accompanied him down to the king. 16 He said to the king, "This is what Yahweh says: 'Because you sent messengers to inquire of Baal-zebub, the god of Ekron, as though there were no God in Israel whose word you could seek, you will not come down from the bed you have gone up to. You will surely die.' "

17 So he died according to the word of Yahweh that Elijah had spoken. Jehoram[e] reigned in his place, in the second year of Jehoram son of Jehoshaphat king of Judah, because he had no son.[f] 18 The rest of the acts of Ahaziah, what he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel?[g]

Notes

- a (1:1) Moab, the land east of the Dead Sea. The name was popularly explained as "from father" (Genesis 19:37).
- b (1:2) Baal-zebub means "lord of flies," probably a mocking alteration of Baal-zebul, "Baal the prince." The Septuagint has "Baal Fly."
- c (1:2) Ekron, one of the five Philistine cities, means "uprooting" or "barren place."
- d (1:8) Or "a man with a garment of hair." Hebrew "a lord of hair."
- e (1:17) Jehoram (also spelled Joram) means "Yahweh is exalted."
- f (1:17) The Septuagint lacks everything in this verse after "Elijah had spoken." Compare 3:1, which dates Jehoram of Israel's accession to the eighteenth year of Jehoshaphat.
- g (1:18) The Septuagint adds a summary of Jehoram's reign (1:18a–d): he reigned twelve years from the eighteenth year of Jehoshaphat, did evil but not like his mother, removed the pillars of Baal, yet kept to the sins of Jeroboam; "and Yahweh was very angry with the house of Ahab."

Chapter 2

1 When Yahweh was about to carry Elijah up into heaven by a
whirlwind, Elijah was setting out from Gilgal[a] with Elisha. 2 Elijah
told Elisha, "Please wait here; Yahweh has sent me on to Bethel."[b]
Elisha answered, "By the life of Yahweh and by your own life, I am
not leaving you." So the two of them went down to Bethel. 3 The sons
of the prophets who were at Bethel came out to Elisha and said to
him, "Do you know that today Yahweh is going to take your master
from over you?"[c] He said, "Yes, I know. Keep quiet." 4 Elijah told him,
"Elisha, please wait here; Yahweh has sent me on to Jericho." But he
answered, "By the life of Yahweh and by your own life, I am not
leaving you." So they arrived at Jericho. 5 The prophets' sons at Jericho
drew near to Elisha and asked him, "Are you aware that Yahweh will
take your master away from you today?" "Yes, I am aware of it," he
said. "Say nothing." 6 Then Elijah said to him, "Stay here, please, for
Yahweh has sent me to the Jordan." But he said, "As Yahweh lives, and
as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So the pair of them walked
on. 7 Fifty of the prophets' sons followed and took a position some
distance away, facing the two men as they stood beside the Jordan.
8 Then Elijah took his cloak, rolled it up, and struck the water. The
water parted to one side and the other, and the two of them crossed
over on dry ground.
9 When they had crossed, Elijah said to Elisha, "Before I am taken
from you, say what you would have me do for you." Elisha said, "Let
a double share[d] of your spirit come to me, I pray." 10 He said, "What
you ask is difficult. But if you see me while I am being taken from
you, you shall have it; if you do not, you shall not." 11 As they went on,
walking and talking, suddenly a chariot of fire and horses of fire came
between the two of them, and Elijah went up in the whirlwind into
heaven. 12 Elisha was watching, and he kept crying out, "My father,
my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" Then he saw him
no more. He took hold of his own clothes and tore them in two.
13 He lifted Elijah's cloak, which had dropped from him, and went back
and stood on the Jordan's bank. 14 He took the cloak of Elijah that
had fallen from him, struck the water, and said, "Where is Yahweh,

the God of Elijah?" When he too had struck the water, it parted to one side and the other, and Elisha crossed over.[e] 15 When the sons of the prophets who were at Jericho saw him from across the river,[f] they said, "The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha." They came to meet him and bowed to the ground before him. 16 They said to him, "Look, your servants have fifty capable men with them. Please let them go and search for your master. It may be that Yahweh's Spirit has lifted him and dropped him on a mountain somewhere or in a valley." He said, "Do not send them." 17 But they kept pressing him until he was ashamed to refuse, and he said, "Send them." They sent fifty men, and for three days they searched for him without finding him. 18 When they returned to Elisha, who was still staying in Jericho, he said to them, "Didn't I warn you not to go?"

19 The men of the city said to Elisha, "Look, the city is well situated, as my lord can see, but the water is bad and the land causes miscarriages."[g] 20 He said, "Fetch me a new bowl with salt in it." And they fetched it for him. 21 He went out to the spring and threw the salt into it and said, "This is what Yahweh says: 'I have healed this water. From now on it will no longer cause death or miscarriage.' " 22 So the water has stayed wholesome to this day, according to the word that Elisha spoke.

23 From there he went up to Bethel. While he was going up the road, some young boys[h] came out of the town and jeered at him, saying, "Go on up, baldhead! Go on up, baldhead!" 24 He turned around, looked at them, and cursed them in the name of Yahweh. Then two she-bears came out of the woods and mauled forty-two of the boys. 25 From there he went on to Mount Carmel, and from there he returned to Samaria.

Notes

- a (2:1) Gilgal means "circle (of stones)." This Gilgal was probably in the hills north of Bethel, not the one near Jericho.
- b (2:2) Bethel means "house of God."
- c (2:3) Hebrew "from over your head," that is, from being your master; likewise in verse 5.
- d (2:9) Hebrew "a mouth of two," the firstborn son's portion of an inheritance (Deuteronomy 21:17).

- e (2:14) Hebrew 'aph-hu', "he too." Some take it with the preceding question: "Where is Yahweh, the God of Elijah, indeed?"
- f (2:15) Hebrew "from opposite."
- g (2:19) Or "is barren." Hebrew meshakkalet, "bereaving"; likewise in verse 21.
- h (2:23) Hebrew ne'arim qetannim, "small youths"; the term can cover boys or young men.

Chapter 3

1 In the eighteenth year of Jehoshaphat king of Judah, Jehoram son
of Ahab began to reign over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned twelve
years. 2 He did evil in Yahweh's sight, though not to the extent of his
father and mother, for he took away the sacred stone of Baal that his
father had set up. 3 Yet he clung to the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat,
by which he had made Israel sin; he did not turn from them.
4 Mesha[a] king of Moab raised sheep, and as tribute he delivered to
Israel's king a hundred thousand lambs and the wool of a hundred
thousand rams. 5 But when Ahab died, the king of Moab rebelled
against the king of Israel. 6 So King Jehoram marched out of Samaria
at that time and mustered all Israel. 7 He also sent this message to
Jehoshaphat, Judah's king: "Moab's king has revolted against me. Will
you join me in war against Moab?" He replied, "I will go up. You and
I are one; my people are yours, and my horses are yours." 8 He asked,
"By which road shall we go up?" Jehoram answered, "By the road
through the wilderness of Edom."[b]
9 So the king of Israel marched out together with the kings of Judah
and Edom. After a winding route of seven days, the army and the
animals that followed them had run out of water. 10 "What a disaster!"
exclaimed the king of Israel. "Yahweh has summoned these three
kings only to deliver us into Moab's power." 11 Jehoshaphat asked,
"Isn't there a prophet of Yahweh here, so that we can seek Yahweh's
will through him?" An officer of the king of Israel replied, "Elisha
son of Shaphat is here; he used to pour water over Elijah's hands."
12 Jehoshaphat said, "The word of Yahweh is with him." So the king
of Israel and Jehoshaphat and the king of Edom went down to him.
13 Elisha said to the king of Israel, "What have I to do with you?[c]
Take yourself to the prophets of your father and your mother." The

king of Israel replied, "Do not say that. Yahweh has called these three kings together to hand them over to Moab." 14 Elisha said, "As Yahweh of hosts lives, before whom I stand, if I did not have regard for Jehoshaphat king of Judah, I would not look at you or even see you. 15 But now bring me a musician." And while the musician played, the hand of Yahweh came on him. 16 He said, "This is what Yahweh says: 'Make this wadi full of pools.'[d] 17 For this is what Yahweh says: 'You will see no wind and you will see no rain, yet this wadi will be filled with water, and you will drink, you, your cattle, and your animals.' 18 This is only a small thing in the sight of Yahweh; he will also give Moab into your hand. 19 You will attack every walled city and every important town. You will cut down every good tree, block every spring, and spoil every good field by covering it with stones." 20 The next morning, when the grain offering[e] was due, water suddenly flowed in from the direction of Edom, and the ground was covered with it.

21 When all the Moabites heard that the kings had come up to fight against them, everyone old enough to put on armor, and older, was called out and stationed at the border. 22 They got up at dawn, and as the sun rose over the water, the Moabites looked across and saw the water red like blood. 23 "Blood!" they said. "The kings must have turned their swords on each other[f] and slaughtered one another. On to the spoil, Moab!" 24 But when they came to the camp of Israel, the Israelites rose up and struck the Moabites, who fled before them. They pressed on into the land, striking Moab as they went.[g] 25 They tore down the towns. On every good field each man threw a stone, until it was covered. They stopped up every spring and felled every good tree, until only the stones of Kir-hareseth[h] were left, and the slingers surrounded it and attacked it. 26 When Moab's king saw that the fighting was too strong for him, he took seven hundred men who could wield the sword and tried to break through toward the king of Edom, but they failed. 27 Then he took his firstborn son, who was to reign after him, and sacrificed him as a burnt offering on the wall. Great wrath[i] fell on Israel, and they pulled back from him and went home to their land.

Notes

- a (3:4) Mesha may mean "salvation." His own inscription, the Moabite Stone (about 840 B.C.), tells of Moab's revolt from the Moabite side.
- b (3:8) Edom, "red," the land south of the Dead Sea.
- c (3:13) Hebrew "What to me and to you?"
- d (3:16) Or "trenches." Hebrew "Make this wadi pits, pits."
- e (3:20) Hebrew "at the going up of the minchah," the morning grain offering.
- f (3:23) Hebrew uncertain; perhaps "have surely put each other to the sword."
- g (3:24) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; some ancient witnesses read "they went on striking."
- h (3:25) Kir-hareseth means "city of potsherds" or "wall of potsherds." It is probably modern Kerak in Jordan.
- i (3:27) Hebrew qetseph, "wrath, fury." Whose wrath is not stated.

Chapter 4

1 Now the wife of one of the sons of the prophets cried out to
Elisha, "Your servant my husband is dead, and you know that your
servant feared Yahweh. But now the creditor has come to take my
two children as his slaves." 2 Elisha said to her, "What can I do for
you? Tell me, what do you have in the house?" She said, "Your servant
has nothing in the house except a flask of oil." 3 He said, "Go around
to your neighbors and borrow jars from all of them, empty ones, as
many as you can. 4 Then go in and shut the door behind you and your
sons, and pour oil into all these vessels. As each is filled, set it aside."
5 So she went from him and closed the door on herself and her sons.
While they brought her the jars, she went on pouring. 6 When all the
jars were full, she said to her son, "Bring me one more jar." But he
replied, "There isn't another one." And then the oil ceased. 7 She came
and told the man of God, and he said, "Go, sell the oil and pay your
debt, and you and your sons can live on the rest."
8 One day Elisha passed through Shunem,[a] where a wealthy woman
lived, and she urged him to eat a meal. After that, every time he came
by, he stopped there for a meal. 9 She told her husband, "I can tell
that the man who regularly comes by here is a holy man of God. 10
Let us make a small walled room on the roof and put a bed, a table,
a chair, and a lamp there for him. Then whenever he comes to us, he
can stay there."

11 One day he arrived, went up into the roof room, and lay down to
rest. 12 He said to his servant Gehazi,[b] "Call this Shunammite woman."
He called her, and she stood before him. 13 He said to Gehazi, "Say
to her, 'You have gone to all this trouble for us. What may we do in
return? Would you like a word put in for you with the king or the
army commander?' " She answered, "I live among my own people." 14
He said, "What then can be done for her?" Gehazi answered, "Well,
she has no son, and her husband is old." 15 He said, "Call her." When he
had called her, she stood in the doorway. 16 He said, "At this season,
when the time comes round, you will be holding a son in your arms."
She said, "No, my lord, man of God, do not deceive your servant." 17
But the woman conceived and bore a son at that season, when the
time came round, as Elisha had told her.
18 The child grew, and one day he went out to join his father, who
was with the reapers. 19 He said to his father, "My head, my head!"
His father said to a servant, "Carry him to his mother." 20 The servant
lifted him and carried him to his mother. The boy sat on her lap until
noon, and then he died. 21 She went up, laid him on the bed of the man
of God, shut the door on him, and went out. 22 Then she called to her
husband and said, "Please send me one of the servants and one of the
donkeys, so that I may hurry to the man of God and come back." 23 He
said, "Why are you going to him today? It is neither new moon nor
Sabbath." She said, "It is all right."[c] 24 Then she saddled the donkey and
said to her servant, "Drive on, go! Do not slow down for me unless
I tell you." 25 So she set out and came to the man of God at Mount
Carmel. When the man of God caught sight of her far off, he told
Gehazi his servant, "There is the Shunammite woman. 26 Run now to
meet her and ask her, 'Are you well? Is your husband well? Is the
child well?' " She answered, "All is well." 27 When she reached the man
of God at the mountain, she grabbed his feet. Gehazi stepped forward
to shove her aside, but the man of God said, "Let her be. She is deeply
troubled, and Yahweh has kept the reason from me; he hasn't told
me." 28 Then she said, "Was it I who asked my lord for a son? Did I
not tell you, 'Do not raise my hopes'?"[d] 29 He said to Gehazi, "Tuck
up your robe, take my staff, and be off. Greet no one you meet, and

answer no one who greets you. Lay my staff on the boy's face." 30 But
the child's mother said, "As Yahweh lives, and as you yourself live, I
will not leave you." So Elisha rose and went with her. 31 Gehazi hurried
on ahead and set the staff on the boy's face, yet there was no voice
and no sign of life. So he turned back to meet Elisha and reported,
"The child did not wake up."
32 When Elisha came into the house, there was the boy, dead, lying on
his bed. 33 He went in and closed the door behind the two of them,
and he prayed to Yahweh. 34 Then he got up on the bed and lay on the
child, putting his mouth on his mouth, his eyes on his eyes, and his
hands on his hands. As he stretched himself over him, the child's body
grew warm. 35 Then he got down and paced to and fro in the house
once, then went up and stretched himself over him again. Seven
times the boy sneezed, and then his eyes opened. 36 Elisha summoned
Gehazi and said, "Call the Shunammite." Gehazi called her, and when
she entered the room, Elisha said, "Pick up your son." 37 She entered,
dropped at his feet, and bowed low to the ground. Then she took her
son and left the room.
38 Elisha returned to Gilgal while there was a famine in the land. As the
sons of the prophets were sitting before him, he said to his servant,
"Put the large pot on and boil a stew for the sons of the prophets." 39
One man went out to the countryside to gather herbs. There he found
a wild vine and filled the fold of his cloak with its wild gourds.[e] He
returned and sliced them into the stew pot, though no one knew what
they were. 40 They served it to the men, but when the men began to
eat the stew, they shouted, "Man of God, death is in the pot!" They
were unable to eat it. 41 Elisha said, "Bring me flour," and he tossed it
into the pot. "Pour it out for the people to eat," he said. And there was
nothing harmful in the pot.
42 A man from Baal-shalishah[f] arrived with twenty barley loaves made
from the first harvest, and some fresh grain in his bag,[g] for the man
of God. Elisha said, "Hand it out for the people to eat." 43 His servant
objected, "How am I supposed to serve this to a hundred men?" Elisha
repeated, "Hand it out for the people to eat. This is what Yahweh says:
'They will eat, and there will be food left over.' " 44 So he set it before

them, and they ate and had some left over, according to the word of Yahweh.

Notes

- a (4:8) Shunem, in the Jezreel Valley, near modern Sulam; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- b (4:12) Gehazi may mean "valley of vision."
- c (4:23) Hebrew "Shalom," "peace"; likewise in verse 26.
- d (4:28) Or "Do not deceive me."
- e (4:39) Probably colocynth, a bitter and purgative wild gourd.
- f (4:42) Baal-shalishah means "lord of Shalishah," "the third." It lay near Gilgal in the hill country of Ephraim.
- g (4:42) The meaning of the Hebrew word translated "in his sack" is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "and cakes of figs."

Chapter 5

1 Naaman,[a] commander of the army of the king of Aram, was a great
man in his master's eyes and highly regarded, because through him
Yahweh had given victory to Aram. He was a mighty warrior, but
he had a serious skin disease.[b] 2 Now the Arameans had gone out on
raids and had taken captive a young girl from the land of Israel, and
she served Naaman's wife. 3 She told her mistress, "I wish my master
could go to the prophet in Samaria. He would rid him of his skin
disease." 4 So Naaman went in and told his lord, "This is what the girl
from the land of Israel said." 5 The king of Aram said, "Go now, and I
will send a letter to the king of Israel." So he went, taking with him
about 750 pounds of silver,[c] about 150 pounds of gold,[d] and ten sets
of clothing. 6 The letter he delivered to Israel's king said: "Along with
this letter comes my servant Naaman, whom I have sent so that you
may rid him of his skin disease." 7 When the king of Israel read the
letter, he tore his clothes and said, "Am I God, to kill and to make alive,
that this man sends me word to cure someone of his skin disease?
Just look and see how he is seeking a quarrel with me."
8 When Elisha the man of God heard that the king of Israel had
ripped his garments, he sent this message to the king: "Why did you
rip your garments? Send the man to me, and he will find out that
there is a prophet in Israel." 9 So Naaman arrived with his horses and
chariots and stopped at the entrance of Elisha's house. 10 Elisha sent a

messenger out to him, saying, "Go, bathe in the Jordan seven times. Then your flesh will become sound again, and you will be clean." 11 But Naaman grew angry and went away, saying, "I thought that surely he would come out to me, stand and call on the name of Yahweh his God, wave his hand over the place, and cure the disease. 12 Are not Abana[e] and Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them and be clean?" So he turned and went off in a rage. 13 But his servants came near and said to him, "My father,[f] had the prophet ordered some hard thing, you would have done it, would you not? All the more, then, since all he says is, 'Bathe and be clean.' " 14 So Naaman went down and dipped himself in the Jordan seven times, just as the man of God had instructed. His skin became like the skin of a child, and he was clean.

15 He went back to the man of God with all his attendants and stood in front of him. "Now I know," he said, "that nowhere on earth is there a God besides the God of Israel. So I ask you to take a present[g] from your servant." 16 But he said, "As Yahweh lives, before whom I stand, I will accept nothing." Naaman urged him to accept, but he refused. 17 Then Naaman said, "If not, then please let your servant have two mule-loads of soil,[h] because from now on your servant will offer burnt offering or sacrifice to no other god but Yahweh. 18 But in this one matter may Yahweh pardon your servant: when my master enters Rimmon's[i] temple to worship there and leans on my arm, and so I bow down in Rimmon's temple too, when I bow there, may Yahweh pardon your servant in this matter." 19 He said to him, "Go in peace." And when Naaman had gone some distance[j] from him, 20 Gehazi, the servant of Elisha the man of God, said to himself, "See how my master has spared Naaman, this Aramean, by not taking what he offered. As Yahweh lives, I will run after him and get something from him." 21 So Gehazi hurried after Naaman. Naaman, seeing a man running to catch up with him, stepped down from his chariot to meet him. "Is all well?" he asked. 22 "All is well," Gehazi said. "My master sent me with this message: 'Two young men from the company of the prophets have just arrived from the hill country of Ephraim. Please provide them with about 75 pounds of silver[k] and two changes of clothes.' "

23 Naaman said, “Please, take about 150 pounds.”[l] He urged him and
tied up the silver in two bags with two sets of clothing, and handed
them to two of his own servants to carry ahead of Gehazi. 24 When he
came to the hill,[m] he took them from their hands and stored them in
the house. Then he sent the men away, and they left. 25 Gehazi went in
and stood beside his master. Elisha asked him, “Where have you come
from, Gehazi?” “Your servant didn’t go anywhere,” he answered. 26 But
Elisha said, “Was my spirit not there with you when the man stepped
down from his chariot to greet you? Is this the time to take money,
or clothes, or olive groves and vineyards, sheep and cattle, male and
female servants? 27 So Naaman’s skin disease will stick to you and to
your descendants for all time.” Gehazi left Elisha’s presence with a
skin disease as white as snow.

Notes

- a (5:1) Naaman means “pleasant.”
- b (5:1) Hebrew metsora‘, from tsara‘at, traditionally translated “leprosy.” The term covered a range of skin conditions, not only Hansen’s disease; likewise throughout this chapter.
- c (5:5) Hebrew “ten talents of silver.” A talent weighed about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so about 340 kilograms.
- d (5:5) Hebrew “six thousand of gold,” probably shekels. A shekel weighed about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), so about 69 kilograms. The Septuagint reads “six thousand pieces of gold.”
- e (5:12) So the Ketiv; the Qere reads Amanah. Abana may mean “stony”; Pharpar may mean “swift.”
- f (5:13) Hebrew ’avi, “my father,” a respectful address. Some interpreters read the consonants instead as “if.”
- g (5:15) Hebrew berakah, “blessing.”
- h (5:17) Hebrew “a load of a pair of mules.” The Septuagint adds “of the red earth.”
- i (5:18) Rimmon, the Aramean storm god Hadad-Rimmon. The name may mean “thunderer”; Hebrew rimmon also means “pomegranate.”
- j (5:19) Hebrew “a stretch of land,” an uncertain distance.
- k (5:22) Hebrew “a talent of silver.” A talent weighed about 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- l (5:23) Hebrew “two talents,” about 68 kilograms.
- m (5:24) Hebrew ‘ophel, “the hill” or “the citadel.” The Septuagint reads “a secret place.”

Chapter 6

1 The sons of the prophets said to Elisha, “Look, the place where we
live under your charge is too cramped for us. 2 Let us go to the Jordan,
where each of us can cut a beam, and let us build ourselves a place to
live there.” He said, “Go.” 3 Then one of them said, “Please be willing
to come with your servants.” He answered, “I will come.” 4 So he went
with them. When they reached the Jordan, they began cutting down
trees. 5 But as one of them was felling a beam, the iron ax head fell
into the water. He cried out, “Oh no, my master! It was borrowed!”[a]
6 The man of God asked, “Where did it fall?” When he showed him
the place, Elisha cut off a stick, threw it in there, and made the iron
float. 7 “Lift it out,” he said. And the man stretched out his hand and
grabbed it.
8 Once, while Aram’s king was fighting against Israel, he conferred
with his officers and said, “My camp will be at such and such a place.”
9 But the man of God sent this warning to Israel’s king: “Be careful
to avoid that place, because the Arameans are going down there.” 10
The king of Israel sent men to the place the man of God had told him
about. Time and again he warned the king, so that he was on guard
there, more than once or twice. 11 The mind of the king of Aram was
greatly troubled over this. He summoned his officers and demanded,
“Which one of us is siding with Israel’s king? Tell me!” 12 One of his
servants said, “None of us, my lord the king. Elisha, the prophet in
Israel, reports to Israel’s king even what you say in your bedroom.”
13 He said, “Go and find out where he is, so that I may send and seize
him.” He was told, “He is in Dothan.”[b] 14 So he sent horses and chariots
there and a strong force. They came by night and surrounded the city.
15 Early the next morning, the servant of the man of God got up and
went outside. An army with horses and chariots encircled the city.
“Oh, my master, what are we going to do?” the servant asked. 16 He
answered, “Do not be afraid, for those who are with us are more than
those who are with them.” 17 Then Elisha prayed, “Yahweh, please
open his eyes so that he may see.” Yahweh opened the servant’s eyes,
and he saw the mountain full of horses and chariots of fire all around
Elisha. 18 When the Arameans came down against him, Elisha prayed

to Yahweh, “Strike this people with blindness.”[c] And he struck them with blindness, as Elisha had asked. 19 Elisha told them, “You are on the wrong road, and this is the wrong city. Come after me, and I will lead you to the man you seek.” And he took them to Samaria.
20 As soon as they had entered Samaria, Elisha said, “Yahweh, open the eyes of these men so that they may see.” Yahweh opened their eyes, and they saw that they were inside Samaria. 21 When the king of Israel saw them, he said to Elisha, “Shall I strike them down, my father? Shall I strike them down?” 22 “Don’t kill them,” he answered. “Would you kill men you did not capture with your own sword and bow?[d] Set food and water in front of them so that they can eat and drink, and send them back to their master.” 23 So he prepared a great feast for them. When they had eaten and drunk, he sent them away, and they went to their master. And the Aramean raiding bands stopped coming into the land of Israel.
24 Some time later Ben-hadad king of Aram mustered his whole army, went up, and laid siege to Samaria. 25 There was a great famine in Samaria. The siege went on until a donkey’s head sold for about 2 pounds of silver,[e] and half a pint of dove’s dung[f] for about 2 ounces of silver.[g] 26 As the king of Israel was walking along the city wall, a woman called out to him, “Save me, my lord the king!” 27 He said, “If Yahweh will not save you, where am I to get help for you? From the threshing floor? From the winepress?” 28 The king then said to her, “What is troubling you?” She replied, “This woman told me, ‘Give up your son so that we can eat him today, and we will eat my son tomorrow.’ 29 So we cooked my son and ate him. On the following day I told her, ‘Now it is your son’s turn to be eaten,’ but she has hidden him away.” 30 When the king heard the woman’s words, he tore his clothes. As he was walking along the wall, the people looked, and there was sackcloth underneath, on his body. 31 He said, “May God deal with me, and even more severely, if Elisha son of Shaphat’s head remains on his shoulders by the end of today.”
32 Elisha was seated at home with the elders around him. The king had dispatched a man, but before the messenger got there, Elisha said to the elders, “Do you realize that this murderer’s son has sent a man

to cut off my head? When the messenger arrives, close the door and press against it to keep him out. The sound of his master's steps is right behind him, isn't it?" 33 While he was still speaking with them, the messenger[h] came down to him and said, "This disaster is from Yahweh. Why should I wait for Yahweh any longer?"

Notes

- a (6:5) The Septuagint reads "and it was hidden."
- b (6:13) Dothan means "two wells."
- c (6:18) Hebrew sanwerim, a rare word for a dazzling or confusing blindness (compare Genesis 19:11).
- d (6:22) Or "Do you strike down those you have taken captive with your sword and bow?" that is, even prisoners of war are not killed.
- e (6:25) Hebrew "eighty of silver," probably shekels. A shekel weighed about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), so about 920 grams. The Septuagint reads "fifty pieces of silver."
- f (6:25) Hebrew "a quarter of a kab." A kab was about 1 1/4 quarts (1.2 liters), so about a third of a liter. "Dove's dung" may be a popular name for a cheap food such as carob pods or wild bulbs.
- g (6:25) Hebrew "five of silver," probably shekels, about 57 grams.
- h (6:33) So the Hebrew and the Septuagint. Many interpreters read "the king," since the king seems to be speaking (compare 7:2, 17).

Chapter 7

1 Elisha said, "Hear the word of Yahweh. This is what Yahweh says: 'About this time tomorrow, at the gate of Samaria, 7 quarts of fine flour will sell for about 2/5 ounce of silver, and 14 quarts of barley for 2/5 ounce.' "[a] 2 The officer on whose arm the king leaned answered the man of God, "Even if Yahweh were to make windows in the sky, could this happen?" Elisha said, "Your own eyes will see it happen, but not a bite of it will you eat."

3 At the entrance to the city gate sat four men who had a serious skin disease.[b] They said to each other, "Why should we stay here until we die? 4 If we decide to go into the city, we will die there, since famine is inside. If we keep sitting here, we die all the same. So come, let us desert to the Aramean camp. Should they let us live, we live; and if they kill us, we will only die." 5 So at dusk they got up and headed for the Arameans' camp. Yet when they reached its outskirts, not a soul was to be found. 6 For the Lord[c] had caused the Aramean army

to hear what sounded like chariots, horses, and a vast army, and they told each other, "Israel's king must have paid the Hittite kings and the Egyptian[d] kings to come against us!" 7 So at dusk they had run off, leaving behind tents, horses, and donkeys, the whole camp as it stood, to save their lives. 8 When these men with the disease reached the far side of the camp, they went into a tent, ate and drank, and took silver, gold, and garments from it, and went off to hide them. Then they returned and entered a second tent, took things from it, and hid those as well.

9 But then they said to each other, "What we are doing is wrong. Today is a day for good news, yet we are saying nothing. If we wait until dawn, we will be punished. Let's go now and report to the royal household." 10 So they went and shouted up to the city's gatekeepers, "We have been to the Arameans' camp, and there was no one there, not a human voice, only the horses tied up, the donkeys tied up, and the tents just as they were." 11 The gatekeepers called out, and the news was told inside the king's household. 12 The king rose in the night and told his officers, "I will explain to you what the Arameans are up to. They are aware that we are starving. So they have slipped out of their camp and are hiding out in the fields, expecting that we will come out of the city, so that they can capture us alive and get inside." 13 One of his servants replied, "Have men take five of the horses that are left in the city. They will be no worse off than the whole crowd of Israelites remaining here, or the whole crowd of Israelites who have already died.[e] Let's send them out and find out." 14 So they took two chariots with horses, and the king sent them after the Aramean army, saying, "Go and see." 15 They followed them as far as the Jordan, and the whole road was littered with clothing and equipment that the Arameans had thrown away in their haste. The messengers returned and told the king. 16 Then the people went out and plundered the Aramean camp. So 7 quarts of fine flour sold for 2/5 ounce of silver, and 14 quarts of barley for 2/5 ounce, according to the word of Yahweh.

17 Now the king had appointed the officer whose arm he leaned on to take charge of the gate. The crowd trampled him there in the gate, and he died, as the man of God had said when the king came down to

him. 18 For when the man of God had said to the king, “About this time
tomorrow, at the gate of Samaria, 14 quarts of barley will sell for 2/5
ounce of silver, and 7 quarts of fine flour for 2/5 ounce,” 19 the officer
had answered the man of God, “Even if Yahweh opened windows in
heaven, could this come about?” And Elisha had told him, “Your own
eyes will see it happen, but not a bite of it will you eat.” 20 That is just
what happened to him: the people trampled him in the gateway, and
he died.

Notes

- a (7:1) Hebrew “a seah of fine flour for a shekel, and two seahs of barley for a shekel.” A seah was about 7 quarts (about 7.3 liters); a shekel weighed about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams). These were low prices compared with 6:25. Likewise in verses 16 and 18.
- b (7:3) Hebrew metsoraʿim; see the note at 5:1.
- c (7:6) Hebrew Adonai.
- d (7:6) Some interpreters take Hebrew Mitsrayim, “Egypt,” as Musri, a land in Anatolia, alongside the Hittite kings of northern Syria.
- e (7:13) The Hebrew of this verse is repetitive and somewhat uncertain.

Chapter 8

1 Elisha had told the woman whose son he had brought back to life,
“Leave with your family and live as a foreigner wherever you are
able, because Yahweh has summoned a famine that will come upon
the land for seven years.” 2 The woman did what the man of God said.
She left with her family and lived as a foreigner in Philistine territory
for seven years. 3 When the seven years had passed, the woman came
back from Philistine territory and went to make a plea to the king to
get back her house and land. 4 The king was talking with Gehazi, the
servant of the man of God, saying, “Tell me all the great things Elisha
has done.” 5 Just as Gehazi was recounting to the king how Elisha had
brought a dead boy back to life, in came the woman whose son it
was, appealing to the king for her house and her field. Gehazi said,
“My lord the king, this is the woman, and this is her son whom Elisha
restored to life.” 6 When the king questioned the woman, she told him.
So the king assigned an official to her, saying, “Give back everything

that was hers, along with all the produce of the field from the day she left the land until now."
7 Elisha came to Damascus at a time when Ben-hadad, Aram's king, was sick. When the king heard, "The man of God has arrived here," 8 he said to Hazael, "Take a gift with you and go to meet the man of God. Inquire of Yahweh through him, asking, 'Will I recover from this illness?' " 9 Hazael went to meet Elisha with a present: forty camels loaded with every sort of fine product from Damascus. He arrived, stood in front of Elisha, and said, "Your son Ben-hadad king of Aram has sent me to ask, 'Will I recover from this sickness?' " 10 Elisha said to him, "Go and say to him,[a] 'You will certainly recover.' But Yahweh has shown me that he will certainly die." 11 He fixed his gaze on him and stared until he was ashamed.[b] Then the man of God wept. 12 "Why are you crying, my lord?" asked Hazael. Elisha replied, "Because I know what evil you will do to the people of Israel: you will burn down their strongholds, put their young men to the sword, smash their children, and cut open their pregnant women." 13 Hazael said, "What is your servant, a mere dog, that he should do this great thing?" Elisha answered, "Yahweh has shown me that you will be king over Aram." 14 Hazael left Elisha and went back to his master, who asked, "What did Elisha say to you?" "He said that you would surely get well," Hazael replied. 15 But the next day Hazael took the bed cover, dipped it in water, and spread it over the king's face, and he died. And Hazael reigned in his place.
16 In the fifth year of Joram son of Ahab king of Israel, while Jehoshaphat was king of Judah,[c] Jehoram son of Jehoshaphat king of Judah began to reign. 17 He was thirty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned eight years in Jerusalem. 18 He followed the path of Israel's kings, just as Ahab's house did, since he had married a daughter of Ahab. He did evil in Yahweh's sight. 19 Yet Yahweh was unwilling to destroy Judah, for the sake of his servant David, because he had pledged to keep a lamp burning for David and his descendants forever. 20 In his days Edom revolted against Judah's rule and set up a king of their own. 21 Then Joram crossed over to Zair[d] with all his chariots. He rose by night and struck the Edomites who

had surrounded him and his chariot commanders, but his army fled to their tents.[e] 22 So Edom has been in revolt against Judah's rule to this day. At that same time Libnah[f] revolted too. 23 The rest of the acts of Joram and all that he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 24 Joram slept with his fathers and was buried with his fathers in David's city, and Ahaziah his son reigned in his place.

25 In the twelfth year of Joram son of Ahab king of Israel, Ahaziah son of Jehoram king of Judah began to reign. 26 Ahaziah was twenty-two years old when he began to reign, and he reigned one year in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Athaliah,[g] a granddaughter[h] of Omri king of Israel. 27 He walked in the way of Ahab's house and did evil in Yahweh's sight just as Ahab's house had, for he was related by marriage to Ahab's house. 28 He went with Joram son of Ahab to war against Hazael king of Aram at Ramoth-gilead, and the Arameans wounded Joram. 29 King Joram went back to Jezreel to be healed of the wounds that the Arameans had given him at Ramah,[i] when he fought against Hazael king of Aram. And Ahaziah son of Jehoram king of Judah went down to see Joram son of Ahab in Jezreel, because he was wounded.

Notes

- a (8:10) So the Qere and many ancient witnesses; the Ketiv reads "Go and say, 'You will certainly not recover.' "
- b (8:11) The subject is unclear. Either Elisha stared at Hazael until Hazael was embarrassed, or the reverse.
- c (8:16) The clause "while Jehoshaphat was king of Judah" is in both the Hebrew and the Septuagint, but many interpreters regard it as an accidental repetition from the end of the verse.
- d (8:21) The location of Zair is unknown; 2 Chronicles 21:9 lacks it.
- e (8:21) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult, and the outcome of the battle is unclear.
- f (8:22) Libnah means "whiteness." It was a town in the Shephelah of Judah.
- g (8:26) Athaliah may mean "Yahweh is exalted."
- h (8:26) Hebrew "daughter," here in the sense of female descendant; she was Ahab's daughter (verse 18).
- i (8:29) That is, Ramoth-gilead.

Chapter 9

1 Elisha the prophet summoned one of the sons of the prophets and
said to him, "Tuck up your robe, take this flask of oil in your hand,
and go to Ramoth-gilead. 2 When you arrive, look for Jehu[a] son of
Jehoshaphat son of Nimshi. Go in, get him to rise from among his
companions, and take him into an inner room. 3 Then take the flask of
oil, pour it on his head, and say, 'This is what Yahweh says: I anoint
you king over Israel.' Then open the door and run. Do not linger."
4 So the young man, the young prophet, went to Ramoth-gilead. 5
When he arrived, the army commanders were sitting together. He
said, "I have a message for you, commander." Jehu asked, "For which
of us?" He replied, "For you, commander." 6 Jehu rose and entered the
house. The young prophet poured the oil over his head and declared,
"This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: I am anointing you
king over the people of Yahweh, over Israel. 7 You are to wipe out
the dynasty of your master Ahab. Thus I will exact vengeance from
Jezebel for the blood of my servants the prophets, and for the blood
of every servant of Yahweh. 8 The whole house of Ahab will perish.
I will cut off from Ahab every male in Israel, whether bond or free.[b]
9 I will make the house of Ahab like the house of Jeroboam son of
Nebat and like the house of Baasha son of Ahijah. 10 As for Jezebel,
dogs will eat her in the plot of ground at Jezreel, with nobody to give
her burial." Then he opened the door and ran.
11 When Jehu came out to his master's officers, one asked him, "Is all
well? What did this madman want with you?" He answered, "You
know the man and the way he talks." 12 They said, "That is not true!
Tell us." So he said, "He told me such and such, and said, 'This is what
Yahweh says: I anoint you king over Israel.' " 13 At once every one of
them took off his cloak and laid it beneath Jehu on the bare steps.[c]
Then they sounded the ram's horn and shouted, "Jehu has become
king!"
14 That is how Jehu son of Jehoshaphat, the son of Nimshi, plotted
against Joram. (Joram and all Israel had been defending Ramoth-
gilead against King Hazael of Aram, 15 but King Joram had gone back
to Jezreel to be healed of the wounds the Arameans had given him

when he fought with Hazael king of Aram. Jehu said, “If this is your wish, let no one slip out of the city to go and report this in Jezreel.”
16 Then Jehu got into his chariot and drove to Jezreel, where Joram was recovering and where Ahaziah king of Judah had gone to visit him. 17 The lookout standing on the tower in Jezreel saw Jehu’s troops coming and said, “I see a body of troops.” Joram ordered, “Send a horseman out to them to ask, ‘Is it peace?’ ”
18 So the horseman rode out to meet him and said, “The king asks, ‘Is it peace?’ ” Jehu said, “What do you care about peace? Fall in behind me.” The lookout reported, “The messenger reached them, but he is not coming back.”
19 Then he sent a second horseman, who came to them and said, “The king asks, ‘Is it peace?’ ” Jehu answered, “What do you care about peace? Fall in behind me.” 20 Again the lookout reported, “He got to them, and he is not returning either. The chariot driver must be Jehu son of Nimshi, for he drives like a madman.”
21 Joram said, “Harness the chariot.” When it was harnessed, Joram king of Israel and Ahaziah king of Judah set out, each riding his own chariot, to confront Jehu, and they encountered him by the land that had belonged to Naboth the Jezreelite. 22 When Joram saw Jehu, he asked, “Is it peace, Jehu?” He answered, “How can there be peace, as long as the whoring and the many sorceries of your mother Jezebel go on?” 23 Joram turned his chariot around[d] and fled, shouting to Ahaziah, “Treachery, Ahaziah!” 24 Jehu drew his bow with all his strength and hit Joram between the shoulders. The arrow came out through his heart, and he slumped down in his chariot. 25 Jehu said to Bidkar his officer, “Pick him up and throw him onto the plot of the field of Naboth the Jezreelite. Remember how you and I were riding side by side behind Ahab his father, when Yahweh uttered this oracle[e] against him: 26 ‘I swear that yesterday I saw the blood of Naboth and of his sons, declares Yahweh, and I will pay you back in this same field, declares Yahweh.’ So pick him up now and throw him into that field, in keeping with Yahweh’s word.”
27 When Ahaziah king of Judah saw this, he fled toward Beth-haggan.[f] Jehu chased him and shouted, “Shoot him too!” And they shot him[g] in his chariot on the ascent to Gur, near Ibleam. He fled to Megiddo

and died there. [28] His servants carried him in a chariot to Jerusalem
and buried him in his tomb with his ancestors in the city of David.
[29] In the eleventh[h] year of Joram son of Ahab, Ahaziah had become
king over Judah.
[30] Jehu then entered Jezreel, and Jezebel heard about it. She put
makeup on her eyes,[i] arranged her hair, and gazed down from a
window. [31] As Jehu entered the gateway, she called out, "Have you
come in peace, Zimri, you murderer of your master?"[j] [32] He looked up
at the window and said, "Who is on my side? Who?" Two or three
eunuchs looked down at him. [33] He said, "Throw her down!" So they
threw her down, and some of her blood spattered on the wall and on
the horses, and they trampled her. [34] Then he went in, ate and drank,
and said, "See to this cursed woman and bury her, for she was a king's
daughter." [35] But when they went to bury her, they found nothing of
her except the skull, the feet, and the palms of her hands. [36] They came
back and told him, and he said, "This is the word of Yahweh, which he
spoke through his servant Elijah the Tishbite: 'In the plot of ground
at Jezreel the dogs will eat the flesh of Jezebel. [37] Jezebel's corpse will
be like dung on the open field in the plot of ground at Jezreel, so that
nobody can say, This is Jezebel.' "

Notes

- a (9:2) Jehu means "Yahweh is he."
- b (9:8) Hebrew ʿatsur weʿazub; see the note at 1 Kings 14:10.
- c (9:13) The meaning of Hebrew gerem ha-maʿaloth, here "bare steps," is uncertain; it may mean "the top of the stairs."
- d (9:23) Hebrew "turned his hands," that is, wheeled the chariot by its reins.
- e (9:25) Hebrew massa', "burden," a word used for a solemn prophetic pronouncement.
- f (9:27) Beth-haggan means "house of the garden"; it is probably modern Jenin.
- g (9:27) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Hebrew lacks "And they shot him."
- h (9:29) 8:25 gives the twelfth year; the two figures reflect different ways of reckoning and are left unchanged.
- i (9:30) Hebrew "set her eyes in antimony," a dark eye paint.
- j (9:31) Zimri killed his master King Elah and reigned only seven days (1 Kings 16:9–18).

Chapter 10

1 Ahab had seventy sons in Samaria. So Jehu wrote letters and sent
them to Samaria, to the officials of Jezreel,[a] to the elders, and to the
guardians of Ahab's sons. He wrote: 2 "You have your master's sons
with you, along with chariots, horses, a walled city, and weapons.
So as soon as this letter arrives, 3 pick the best and most capable of
your master's sons, set him on his father's throne, and fight for your
master's house." 4 But they were terrified and said, "Two kings could
not hold out against him. How can we?" 5 So the palace administrator,
the governor of the city, the elders, and the guardians sent word to
Jehu: "We are at your service and will carry out every order you give.
We are not going to crown anyone. Act as you think best." 6 Then he
wrote them a second letter: "If you side with me and will heed my
voice, bring the heads of your master's sons with you and report to
me in Jezreel about this time tomorrow." The seventy princes were
then being raised by the city's prominent men. 7 When the letter
reached them, they took the king's sons and slaughtered all seventy.
They put their heads in baskets and sent them to him at Jezreel. 8
When the messenger came and told him, "They have brought the
heads of the king's sons," he said, "Pile them in two heaps at the
entrance of the gate until morning." 9 In the morning he went out,
took his stand, and declared to all the people, "You are blameless. I
am the one who plotted against my master and slew him. Yet who
killed every one of these? 10 Know, then, that not one word of Yahweh
that Yahweh spoke against the house of Ahab will fall to the ground.
Yahweh has done what he said through his servant Elijah." 11 So Jehu
struck down all who were left of the house of Ahab in Jezreel, all his
leading men, his close friends, and his priests, until he left him no
survivor.
12 Then he set out and went toward Samaria. On the way, at Beth-
eked of the Shepherds,[b] 13 Jehu came upon relatives of Ahaziah king of
Judah. He asked, "Who are you?" They answered, "We are Ahaziah's
relatives, and we have come down to greet the sons of the king and
the sons of the queen mother." 14 He said, "Take them alive." So they

took them alive and slaughtered them at the pit of Beth-eked, forty-two men. He did not spare any of them.

15 Leaving there, he met Jehonadab[c] son of Rechab coming toward him. Jehu greeted him and asked, "Are you as faithful to me as I am to you?" "I am," Jehonadab answered. Jehu said,[d] "Then give me your hand." Jehonadab gave him his hand, and Jehu pulled him up beside him in the chariot. 16 He said, "Come with me and see my zeal for Yahweh." So he had him ride in his chariot. 17 On reaching Samaria, he killed everyone left in Samaria from Ahab's family until none remained, just as Yahweh had told Elijah.

18 Then Jehu gathered all the people and said to them, "Ahab served Baal a little. Jehu will serve him a great deal. 19 Now call together for me all of Baal's prophets, all who serve him, and all his priests. Not one may be absent, because I am holding a great sacrifice for Baal. Whoever fails to come will die." But Jehu was acting deceitfully in order to destroy those who served Baal. 20 Jehu ordered, "Proclaim a sacred assembly for Baal." So they proclaimed it. 21 Jehu sent word throughout Israel, and all the worshipers of Baal came. Not one stayed away. They entered the house of Baal, and it was filled from one end to the other. 22 He said to the keeper of the wardrobe, "Bring out robes for all the worshipers of Baal." So he brought out robes for them. 23 Then Jehu and Jehonadab son of Rechab entered Baal's temple. Jehu told those who served Baal, "Look carefully and make sure that no servant of Yahweh is here with you; only those who serve Baal may be here." 24 Then they went in to offer sacrifices and burnt offerings. Jehu had posted eighty men outside and said, "If any of the men I am handing over to you escapes, the one who lets him go will pay with his own life."

25 As soon as Jehu had completed the burnt offering, he told the guards and officers, "Go in and strike them down; do not let anyone escape." They killed them with swords and threw out the bodies. Then the guards and officers went into the inner room[e] of Baal's temple. 26 They brought out the sacred pillar[f] of the house of Baal and burned it. 27 They demolished the pillar of Baal, tore down the house of Baal, and made it a latrine,[g] as it is to this day. 28 Thus Jehu wiped out Baal from

Israel. 29 Even so, Jehu did not abandon the sins that Jeroboam son
of Nebat had led Israel into: the golden calves in Bethel and Dan. 30
Yahweh said to Jehu, "Because you have done well in carrying out
what is right in my eyes, and have done to the house of Ahab all that
was in my heart, your sons will sit on the throne of Israel to the fourth
generation." 31 But Jehu was not careful to walk in the law of Yahweh
the God of Israel wholeheartedly. He never departed from Jeroboam's
sins, by which he made Israel sin.
32 In those days Yahweh started to trim away pieces of Israel.[h] Hazael
struck them down in every border region of Israel, 33 from the Jordan
eastward, all the land of Gilead, the Gadites, the Reubenites, and
the Manassites, from Aroer by the Wadi Arnon, that is, Gilead and
Bashan. 34 The other events of Jehu's reign, everything he did and all
his power, are written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel.
35 Jehu slept with his ancestors, and they buried him in Samaria. And
Jehoahaz[i] his son reigned in his place. 36 The time Jehu reigned over
Israel in Samaria was twenty-eight years.

Notes

- a (10:1) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "Samaria." Some interpreters suggest "the city."
- b (10:12) Or "the shearing house of the shepherds." Beth-eked means "house of binding," perhaps a place where sheep were tied for shearing.
- c (10:15) Jehonadab means "Yahweh is generous." His descendants, the Rechabites, appear in Jeremiah 35.
- d (10:15) So the Septuagint; the Hebrew lacks "Jehu said."
- e (10:25) Hebrew "to the city of the house of Baal"; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps the inner sanctuary or citadel.
- f (10:26) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Hebrew reads the plural "pillars" with "burned it."
- g (10:27) So the Qere; the Ketiv reads a cruder word for the same thing.
- h (10:32) Or "to reduce Israel."
- i (10:35) Jehoahaz means "Yahweh has grasped."

Chapter 11

1 When Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead,
she set out to destroy the entire royal family. 2 But Jehosheba,[a] King
Joram's daughter and Ahaziah's sister, took Joash[b] son of Ahaziah

and stole him away from among the king's sons who were about to be murdered. She hid the boy and his nurse in a sleeping room, out of Athaliah's reach, and he was not killed. 3 He stayed hidden with her in Yahweh's house for six years, while Athaliah ruled over the land.
4 In the seventh year Jehoiada[c] sent for the commanders of hundreds of the Carites[d] and of the guards and brought them to him in Yahweh's house. He made a covenant with them, put them under oath in Yahweh's house, and showed them the king's son. 5 He gave them these orders: "Here is your assignment. The third of you who begin your duty on the Sabbath will keep watch over the king's palace, 6 one third will be at the Sur Gate, and one third at the gate behind the guards. You will keep watch over the palace in turns.[e] 7 Your two divisions that go off duty on the Sabbath will keep watch over Yahweh's house for the king. 8 Surround the king, each of you with weapons in hand. Whoever comes near your lines must die. Keep close to the king as he comes and goes."
9 The commanders of hundreds did just as Jehoiada the priest ordered. Each took his men, both the Sabbath shift coming on and the Sabbath shift going off, and came to Jehoiada the priest. 10 The priest handed out to the commanders the spears and small shields that once belonged to King David and were kept in Yahweh's house. 11 The guards took up their positions, each with weapon in hand, from the south side of the house to the north side, around the altar and the house, all around the king. 12 Jehoiada led out the king's son, set the crown on his head, and gave him the covenant document.[f] They proclaimed him king and anointed him; then they clapped and shouted, "May the king live!"
13 Athaliah heard the noise made by the guards and the crowd and went to the people gathered at Yahweh's house. 14 She looked, and there was the king, stationed beside the pillar according to custom, the officers and trumpeters at his side, while the people of the land were all celebrating and sounding trumpets. Athaliah ripped her garments and shouted, "Conspiracy! Conspiracy!" 15 Jehoiada the priest commanded the officers in charge of the troops: "Bring her out through the ranks, and put to the sword anyone who follows her."

The priest had said, “She must not be killed at Yahweh’s house.” 16 So
they seized her, and she went by the way of the horses’ entrance to
the king’s palace, and there she was put to death.
17 Jehoiada made a covenant between Yahweh and the king and the
people, that they would be Yahweh’s people, and also between the
king and the people. 18 Then all the people of the land went to the
house of Baal and tore it down. They smashed its altars and its images
to pieces, and before the altars they slew Mattan, Baal’s priest. Then
the priest stationed watchmen over Yahweh’s house. 19 He then led
the commanders of hundreds, the Carites, the guards, and the whole
populace, and together they escorted the king down from Yahweh’s
house and went through the guards’ gate to the palace. He took his
seat on the royal throne. 20 All the people of the land celebrated, and
the city was calm, because Athaliah had been put to death by the
sword at the royal palace.
21 Jehoash[g] was seven years old when he became king.

Notes

- a (11:2) Jehosheba means “Yahweh is an oath.” 2 Chronicles 22:11 calls her Jehoshabeath and adds that she was the wife of Jehoiada the priest.
- b (11:2) Joash, also spelled Jehoash (verse 21), means “Yahweh has given.”
- c (11:4) Jehoiada means “Yahweh knows.”
- d (11:4) The Carites were probably foreign mercenaries, perhaps from Caria in Asia Minor.
- e (11:6) The meaning of the Hebrew word rendered “in turns” is uncertain.
- f (11:12) Hebrew ‘eduth, probably a written copy of the covenant law (compare Deuteronomy 17:18).
- g (11:21) Hebrew 12:1. The Hebrew numbers in chapter 12 run one higher than the English.

Chapter 12

1 In the seventh year of Jehu, Jehoash began to reign, and he
reigned forty years in Jerusalem. His mother’s name was Zibiah[a] of
Beersheba. 2 Jehoash did what was right in Yahweh’s eyes all his days,
because Jehoiada the priest instructed him.[b] 3 Yet the high places were
not removed; the people still sacrificed and burned incense on the
high places.

4 Jehoash said to the priests, “All the money brought as holy gifts into
Yahweh’s house, the money each person is assessed,[c] the money from
the valuation of persons, and all the money anyone freely chooses to
bring into Yahweh’s house, 5 let the priests receive, each from his own
contact,[d] and let them repair the house wherever damage is found.”
6 But by the twenty-third year of King Jehoash the priests still had
not repaired the damage to the house. 7 So King Jehoash summoned
Jehoiada the priest and the other priests and said to them, “Why are
you not repairing the damage to the house? From now on take no
more money from your contacts, but hand it over for repairing the
house.” 8 The priests agreed not to collect any more money from the
people, and also not to be the ones to repair the damage to the temple.
9 Then Jehoiada the priest took a chest, bored a hole in its lid, and
set it beside the altar, on the right as one enters Yahweh’s house. The
priests who guarded the threshold put into it all the money brought
into Yahweh’s house. 10 Each time the chest was seen to be well filled
with money, the royal secretary came up with the high priest, and
they bagged[e] and counted the money found in Yahweh’s house. 11
They gave the money that had been weighed out to the men doing
the work, those appointed over Yahweh’s house. These paid it out
to the carpenters and builders who worked on Yahweh’s house, 12
to the masons and stonecutters, and for buying timber and dressed
stone to repair the damage to Yahweh’s house, and for everything
else spent on repairing the house. 13 But no silver basins, snuffers,
sprinkling bowls, trumpets, or any vessels of gold or silver were made
for Yahweh’s house from the money brought into Yahweh’s house.
14 It was given to the workmen, and with it they repaired Yahweh’s
house. 15 They did not ask for an accounting from the men to whom
they handed the money to pay the workers, for they dealt honestly.
16 The money from guilt offerings and sin offerings was not brought
into Yahweh’s house; it belonged to the priests.
17 About that time Hazael king of Aram attacked Gath and took it.
Then Hazael turned his attention to marching against Jerusalem. 18
Jehoash king of Judah took all the sacred objects that his ancestors
Jehoshaphat, Jehoram, and Ahaziah, kings of Judah, had dedicated,

his own sacred gifts, and all the gold found in the treasuries of Yahweh's house and of the king's palace, and sent them to Hazael king of Aram. Then Hazael withdrew from Jerusalem. 19 The rest of the acts of Joash and all that he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 20 His servants rose up, formed a conspiracy, and struck down Joash at Beth-millo,[f] on the road that goes down to Silla.[g] 21 His servants Jozacar[h] son of Shimeath and Jehozabad son of Shomer attacked him, and he died. He was buried with his ancestors in the city of David, and his son Amaziah[i] became king after him.

Notes

- a (12:1) Zibiah means "gazelle." Verse numbers in this chapter follow the English; the Hebrew numbers run one higher.
- b (12:2) Or "did what was right in Yahweh's eyes all the days that Jehoiada the priest instructed him." Compare 2 Chronicles 24:2, 17–22.
- c (12:4) The Hebrew phrase is obscure; it may refer to the census tax (Exodus 30:13) or to money "that passes" as current.
- d (12:5) The meaning of Hebrew makkar, here "contact," is uncertain; it may mean an acquaintance, a donor, or an assessor. The Septuagint reads "from his sale." Likewise in verse 7.
- e (12:10) Or "tied up," that is, in bags; some interpreters read "melted down."
- f (12:20) Beth-millo means "house of the Millo," probably a building on the earth-work terrace in Jerusalem (compare 1 Kings 9:15).
- g (12:20) The location of Silla is unknown. The Septuagint reads "Sela."
- h (12:21) Jozacar means "Yahweh has remembered." The Septuagint reads "Jezir-char." 2 Chronicles 24:26 names the men Zabad and Jehozabad.
- i (12:21) Amaziah means "Yahweh is strong."

Chapter 13

1 In the twenty-third year of Joash son of Ahaziah king of Judah, Jehoahaz son of Jehu became king over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned seventeen years. 2 He did evil in Yahweh's sight and followed the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin; he never turned from them. 3 So Yahweh's anger burned against Israel, and he kept handing them over to Hazael king of Aram and to Ben-hadad son of Hazael throughout that time. 4 Then Jehoahaz pleaded with Yahweh, and Yahweh listened to him, for he saw how the king of Aram was oppressing Israel. 5 Yahweh gave Israel a deliverer,[a] and

they escaped from Aram's grip. So the Israelites lived in their homes[b]
as they had before. 6 Yet they did not turn from the sins of the house
of Jeroboam, by which he made Israel sin, but kept walking in them.
The Asherah pole[c] also stood in Samaria. 7 Jehoahaz had no army left
except fifty horsemen, ten chariots, and ten thousand foot soldiers,
because the king of Aram had wiped out the rest and left them like the
dust trampled on a threshing floor. 8 The rest of the acts of Jehoahaz,
all he did, and his might, are they not written in the Book of the
Annals of the Kings of Israel? 9 Jehoahaz slept with his fathers, and
they buried him in Samaria. And Joash his son reigned in his place.
10 In the thirty-seventh year of Joash king of Judah, Jehoash son of
Jehoahaz became king over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned sixteen
years. 11 He did evil in Yahweh's sight. He did not turn from any of
the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin, but
walked in them. 12 The rest of the acts of Joash, all he did, and the
might with which he fought against Amaziah king of Judah, are they
not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel? 13 Joash
slept with his fathers, and Jeroboam[d] sat on his throne. Joash was
buried in Samaria with the kings of Israel.
14 When Elisha had fallen ill with the illness from which he would die,
Joash king of Israel went down to him and wept over him, crying, "My
father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" 15 Elisha
said to him, "Take a bow and arrows," and he took a bow and arrows.
16 Then he said to the king of Israel, "Grip the bow." When he had
gripped it, Elisha laid his own hands on the king's hands. 17 "Open the
east window," Elisha said, and Joash opened it. "Shoot," said Elisha,
and he shot. Elisha declared, "Yahweh's arrow of victory, the arrow
of victory over Aram! At Aphek you will strike the Arameans down
until they are finished." 18 Elisha then said, "Pick up the arrows," and
the king picked them up. "Strike the ground," Elisha told the king of
Israel. He struck it three times, then stopped. 19 The man of God was
angry with him and said, "You should have struck five or six times.
Then you would have struck Aram until you had made an end of it.
Now you will strike Aram only three times."

20 Elisha died and they buried him. Now Moabite raiders used to come
into the land each spring.[e] 21 Once, as some men were burying a man,
they caught sight of a raiding band, so they threw the man into
Elisha's tomb. When the man touched Elisha's bones, he came to life
and stood up on his feet.
22 Hazael king of Aram oppressed Israel throughout the days of
Jehoahaz. 23 Yet Yahweh showed them favor and pity and turned back
to them because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. He
would not destroy them, and even now he has not thrown them out
of his sight. 24 When Hazael king of Aram died, Ben-hadad his son
reigned in his place. 25 Jehoash son of Jehoahaz then took back from
Ben-hadad son of Hazael the towns that Hazael had seized in battle
from his father Jehoahaz. Joash defeated Ben-hadad three times and
regained the towns of Israel.

Notes

- a (13:5) The deliverer is not named; he may be Jeroboam II (14:27) or an Assyrian king who pressed Aram from the north.
- b (13:5) Hebrew "in their tents."
- c (13:6) Hebrew 'asherah, a wooden pole or image of the goddess Asherah.
- d (13:13) This is Jeroboam II (14:23–29). Jeroboam probably means "may the people increase."
- e (13:20) Hebrew "at the coming of the year," that is, in spring, the season for campaigns (compare 1 Kings 20:22, 26).

Chapter 14

1 In the second year of Joash son of Joahaz king of Israel, Amaziah
son of Joash king of Judah began to reign. 2 He was twenty-five
years old when he became king, and he reigned twenty-nine years
in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Jehoaddin[a] of Jerusalem. 3 He
did what was right in Yahweh's eyes, though not like his ancestor
David. He acted in every way as his father Joash had acted. 4 Yet
the high places were not removed; the people kept sacrificing and
burning incense on them. 5 When he had a secure hold on the royal
power, he put to death the officials who had assassinated his father
the king. 6 But he did not kill the murderers' children, in keeping
with what is written in the Book of the Law of Moses, where Yahweh

commanded, “Parents are not to die for their children, nor children for their parents; each is to die for his own sin.”[b] 7 He killed ten thousand Edomites in the Valley of Salt and captured Sela[c] in battle, and he renamed it Joktheel,[d] the name it still has today.

8 Then Amaziah sent envoys to Jehoash son of Jehoahaz son of Jehu, king of Israel, with this challenge: “Come, let us face each other in battle.” 9 Jehoash king of Israel sent back this reply to Amaziah king of Judah: “A thornbush in Lebanon sent word to a cedar in Lebanon, ‘Give your daughter to my son as his wife.’ Then a wild animal of Lebanon passed by and trampled the thornbush. 10 You have indeed beaten Edom, and now your heart has carried you away. Enjoy your glory, and stay home! Why stir up trouble that will bring you down, and Judah along with you?” 11 But Amaziah would not listen. So Jehoash king of Israel went up, and he and Amaziah king of Judah faced each other at Beth-shemesh,[e] which belongs to Judah. 12 Israel defeated Judah, and every man ran off home.[f] 13 At Beth-shemesh Jehoash king of Israel captured Amaziah king of Judah, son of Jehoash son of Ahaziah. Then he came to Jerusalem and broke down the wall of Jerusalem for about 600 feet,[g] from the Ephraim Gate to the Corner Gate. 14 He carried off all the gold and silver and all the vessels found in Yahweh’s house and in the treasuries of the king’s palace, as well as hostages, and went back to Samaria.

15 The rest of the acts of Jehoash, what he did, his might, and how he fought with Amaziah king of Judah, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel? 16 Jehoash slept with his fathers and was buried in Samaria with the kings of Israel. And Jeroboam his son reigned in his place.

17 Amaziah son of Joash king of Judah lived fifteen years after the death of Jehoash son of Jehoahaz king of Israel. 18 The rest of the acts of Amaziah, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 19 A conspiracy was formed against him in Jerusalem, and he fled to Lachish. But they sent men after him to Lachish, and they killed him there. 20 They carried him back on horses, and he was buried in Jerusalem with his fathers in the city of David. 21 Then all the people of Judah took Azariah,[h] who was sixteen years old, and

made him king in place of his father Amaziah. 22 He rebuilt Elath[i] and
restored it to Judah, after the king had slept with his fathers.
23 In the fifteenth year of Amaziah son of Joash king of Judah,
Jeroboam son of Joash king of Israel began to reign in Samaria, and
he reigned forty-one years. 24 He did evil in Yahweh's sight. He did
not turn from any of the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which
he made Israel sin. 25 It was he who won back Israel's territory, from
Lebo-hamath[j] down to the Sea of the Arabah,[k] as Yahweh the God of
Israel had promised through his servant Jonah[l] son of Amittai, the
prophet from Gath-hepher.[m] 26 For Yahweh had seen how very bitter
Israel's suffering was. Neither bond nor free remained,[n] and Israel
had nobody to help it. 27 Yahweh had not said that he would blot out
Israel's name from under heaven, so he saved them by the hand of
Jeroboam son of Joash.
28 The other events of Jeroboam's reign, including all he did, his
strength, his battles, and how he won back Damascus and Hamath,
which had once belonged to Judah,[o] are written in the Book of the
Annals of the Kings of Israel. 29 Jeroboam slept with his fathers, the
kings of Israel, and Zechariah[p] his son reigned in his place.

Notes

- a (14:2) So the Ketiv; the Qere and 2 Chronicles 25:1 read "Jehoaddan." The name may mean "Yahweh is delight."
- b (14:6) Deuteronomy 24:16.
- c (14:7) Sela means "rock"; it was a stronghold of Edom.
- d (14:7) Joktheel may mean "God destroys" or "God nourishes"; the meaning is uncertain.
- e (14:11) Beth-shemesh means "house of the sun."
- f (14:12) Hebrew "to his tent."
- g (14:13) Hebrew "four hundred cubits." A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters), so about 180 meters.
- h (14:21) Azariah means "Yahweh has helped." He is also called Uzziah (15:13; 2 Chronicles 26:1).
- i (14:22) Elath, at the head of the Gulf of Aqaba, means "terebinths" or "palms."
- j (14:25) Or "the entrance of Hamath," at the northern border.
- k (14:25) That is, the Dead Sea.
- l (14:25) Jonah means "dove." This is the prophet of the book of Jonah.
- m (14:25) Gath-hepher means "winepress of the well," a town in Zebulun.
- n (14:26) Hebrew ʿatsur weʿazub; see the note at 1 Kings 14:10.

- o (14:28) The Hebrew of this clause, literally "to Judah in Israel," is obscure.
- p (14:29) Zechariah means "Yahweh has remembered."

Chapter 15

1 In the twenty-seventh year of Jeroboam king of Israel, Azariah son
of Amaziah king of Judah began to reign. 2 He was sixteen years old
when he became king, and he reigned fifty-two years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Jecoliah[a] of Jerusalem. 3 He did what was right
in Yahweh's eyes, just as his father Amaziah had done in everything.
4 Yet the high places were not removed; the people kept sacrificing
and burning incense on them. 5 Yahweh struck the king with a serious
skin disease,[b] and it lasted until the day he died. He lived in a separate
house,[c] and Jotham[d] the king's son ran the palace and ruled the people
of the land. 6 The rest of the acts of Azariah, all he did, are they not
written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 7 Azariah
slept with his fathers, and they buried him with his fathers in the city
of David. And Jotham his son reigned in his place.
8 In the thirty-eighth year of Azariah king of Judah, Zechariah son of
Jeroboam reigned over Israel in Samaria for six months. 9 He did evil
in Yahweh's sight, as his fathers had done. He did not turn from the
sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin. 10 Shallum
son of Jabesh conspired against him, struck him down in front of the
people,[e] killed him, and reigned in his place. 11 The rest of the acts of
Zechariah are written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel.
12 So the word that Yahweh had spoken to Jehu came true: "Your sons
will sit on the throne of Israel to the fourth generation." And so it
happened.
13 Shallum son of Jabesh began to reign in the thirty-ninth year of
Uzziah[f] king of Judah, and he reigned one full month in Samaria. 14
Then Menahem[g] son of Gadi came up from Tirzah to Samaria, struck
down Shallum son of Jabesh in Samaria, killed him, and reigned in his
place. 15 The rest of the acts of Shallum and the conspiracy he formed
are written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel. 16 At
that time Menahem, setting out from Tirzah, attacked Tiphsah[h] and

everyone in it and its territory, because they would not open their gates to him. He sacked it and ripped open all its pregnant women.
17 In the thirty-ninth year of Azariah king of Judah, Menahem son of Gadi began to reign over Israel, and he reigned ten years in Samaria.
18 He did evil in Yahweh's sight. Throughout his reign he did not turn from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin.
19 Pul[i] king of Assyria came against the land, and Menahem gave Pul about 37 tons of silver,[j] so that Pul would help him tighten his grip on the kingdom. 20 Menahem raised the money from Israel, from all the wealthy men, about 20 ounces of silver[k] from each, to give to the king of Assyria. So the king of Assyria turned back and did not stay in the land. 21 The rest of the acts of Menahem, all he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel? 22 Menahem slept with his fathers, and Pekahiah[l] his son reigned in his place.
23 In the fiftieth year of Azariah king of Judah, Pekahiah son of Menahem began to reign over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned two years. 24 He did evil in Yahweh's sight. He did not turn from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin. 25 His officer Pekah[m] son of Remaliah conspired against him. With fifty men from Gilead, Pekah struck him down at Samaria, in the citadel of the royal palace, together with Argob and Arieh.[n] Pekah killed him and took his place as king. 26 The rest of the acts of Pekahiah, all he did, are written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel.
27 In the fifty-second year of Azariah king of Judah, Pekah son of Remaliah began to reign over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned twenty years. 28 He did evil in Yahweh's sight. He did not turn from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, by which he made Israel sin. 29 In the days of Pekah king of Israel, Tiglath-pileser[o] king of Assyria came and captured Ijon, Abel-beth-maacah, Janoah, Kedesh, Hazor, Gilead, and Galilee, all the land of Naphtali, and he deported the people to Assyria. 30 Hoshea[p] son of Elah plotted against Pekah son of Remaliah, attacked and killed him, and became king in his place in the twentieth year of Jotham son of Uzziah. 31 The rest of the acts of Pekah, all he did, are written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Israel.

32 In the second year of Pekah son of Remaliah king of Israel, Jotham
son of Uzziah king of Judah began to reign. 33 He was twenty-five
years old when he became king, and he reigned sixteen years in
Jerusalem. His mother's name was Jerusha daughter of Zadok. 34 He
did what was right in Yahweh's eyes, just as his father Uzziah had
done in everything. 35 Yet the high places were not removed; the
people kept sacrificing and burning incense on them. He built the
Upper Gate of Yahweh's house. 36 The rest of the acts of Jotham, all
he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings
of Judah? 37 It was in those days that Yahweh first sent Aram's king
Rezin[q] and Remaliah's son Pekah to attack Judah. 38 Jotham slept with
his fathers and was buried with his fathers in the city of David his
ancestor. And Ahaz[r] his son reigned in his place.

Notes

- a (15:2) Jecoliah means "Yahweh is able."
- b (15:5) Hebrew metsora'; see the note at 5:1.
- c (15:5) Hebrew beth ha-hophshith, perhaps "a house of freedom," that is, free from royal duties; the exact sense is uncertain.
- d (15:5) Jotham means "Yahweh is perfect."
- e (15:10) The Hebrew qabol-'am, "before the people," is unusual. The Septuagint reads "in Keblaam," which some take as Ibleam (compare 9:27).
- f (15:13) Uzziah is another name for Azariah; it means "Yahweh is my strength."
- g (15:14) Menahem means "comforter."
- h (15:16) So the Hebrew. Tiphsah was a town on the Euphrates, far from Israel; some ancient witnesses read "Tappuah," and the Septuagint reads "Tirzah."
- i (15:19) Pul was the Babylonian throne name of Tiglath-pileser III (verse 29).
- j (15:19) Hebrew "a thousand talents of silver." A talent weighed about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so about 34,000 kilograms.
- k (15:20) Hebrew "fifty shekels of silver." A shekel weighed about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), so about 575 grams.
- l (15:22) Pekahiah means "Yahweh has opened (the eyes)."
- m (15:25) Pekah means "he has opened (the eyes)."
- n (15:25) The Hebrew of "along with Argob and Arieh" is obscure; the words may be names of people killed with the king or of places, and may have been misplaced from verse 29.
- o (15:29) Tiglath-pileser III reigned in Assyria about 745–727 BC.
- p (15:30) Hoshea means "salvation."
- q (15:37) Rezin is probably Aramaic for "pleasing" or "prince."
- r (15:38) Ahaz means "he has grasped," a short form of Jehoahaz.

Chapter 16

1 In the seventeenth year of Pekah son of Remaliah, Ahaz son of
Jotham king of Judah began to reign. 2 Ahaz was twenty years old
when he became king, and he reigned sixteen years in Jerusalem.
Unlike his ancestor David, he did not do what was right in the eyes
of Yahweh his God. 3 He followed the path of Israel's kings. He even
made his own son go through fire,[a] imitating the disgusting customs
of the nations that Yahweh had expelled ahead of the Israelites. 4 He
sacrificed and burned incense on the high places, on the hills, and
under every leafy tree.
5 Then Rezin king of Aram and Pekah son of Remaliah king of Israel
came up to wage war against Jerusalem. They besieged Ahaz but
could not conquer him.[b] 6 At that time Rezin king of Aram[c] recovered
Elath for Aram and drove the Judeans out of Elath. Then Edomites[d]
came to Elath and have lived there to this day. 7 Ahaz sent envoys to
Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria to say, "I am your servant and your
son. Come up and rescue me from the grasp of the king of Aram
and the king of Israel, who are attacking me." 8 Ahaz took the silver
and gold found in Yahweh's house and in the treasuries of the king's
palace and sent it as a present[e] to the king of Assyria. 9 The king of
Assyria agreed. He marched up against Damascus and captured it,
deported its people to Kir,[f] and put Rezin to death.
10 King Ahaz traveled to Damascus to meet Tiglath-pileser king of
Assyria. There he saw the altar and sent Uriah[g] the priest a sketch
of the altar and detailed plans for its construction. 11 Uriah the priest
built the altar exactly as King Ahaz had instructed from Damascus,
finishing it before King Ahaz came back from Damascus. 12 When the
king arrived from Damascus and saw the altar, he approached the
altar and went up on it. 13 There he offered up his burnt offering and
grain offering, made his drink offering, and dashed against the altar
the blood from his fellowship sacrifices. 14 The bronze altar that stood
before Yahweh he moved from the front of the house, from between
the new altar and Yahweh's house, and put it on the north side of his
altar. 15 King Ahaz commanded Uriah the priest, "Offer the morning
burnt offering and the evening grain offering on the large altar,

together with the king's burnt offering and grain offering, and the burnt offering of all the people of the land with their grain offerings and drink offerings. Sprinkle all the blood of the burnt offerings and the sacrifices on it. The bronze altar will be for me to use for seeking guidance."[h] 16 Uriah the priest did all that King Ahaz commanded.
17 King Ahaz cut away the panels of the stands and took the basins off them. He lowered the Sea from the bronze oxen beneath it and placed it on a stone pavement. 18 Because of the king of Assyria, he removed from Yahweh's house the covered Sabbath passage[i] that had been built in the house, and the king's outer entrance. 19 The rest of the acts of Ahaz, all he did, are they not written in the Book of the Annals of the Kings of Judah? 20 Ahaz slept with his fathers and was buried with his fathers in the city of David. And Hezekiah[j] his son reigned in his place.

Notes

- a (16:3) That is, he offered his son as a burnt sacrifice; compare 3:27 and Deuteronomy 18:10.
- b (16:5) Compare Isaiah 7:1–9.
- c (16:6) Many interpreters read "Rezin king of Aram" as a later addition and "Aram" as "Edom" in this verse, since the two words look alike in Hebrew.
- d (16:6) So the Qere and the Septuagint; the Ketiv reads "Arameans."
- e (16:8) Or "a bribe."
- f (16:9) Kir was the land the Arameans came from (Amos 9:7); its location is unknown.
- g (16:10) Uriah means "Yahweh is my light."
- h (16:15) Or "for me to consider." The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- i (16:18) So the Qere; the meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "a base for the throne."
- j (16:20) Hezekiah means "Yahweh strengthens."

Chapter 17

1 In the twelfth year of Ahaz king of Judah, Hoshea son of Elah began to reign over Israel in Samaria, and he reigned nine years. 2 He did evil in Yahweh's sight, though not to the degree of the kings of Israel who came before him. 3 Shalmaneser[a] king of Assyria marched up against him, and Hoshea became his vassal and paid him tribute. 4 But the king of Assyria discovered that Hoshea was plotting against

him. He had sent envoys to So[b] king of Egypt and had withheld the yearly tribute owed to Assyria's king. So Assyria's king seized him and locked him in prison. 5 Then the king of Assyria invaded the whole land. He went up to Samaria and besieged it for three years. 6 In Hoshea's ninth year, the king of Assyria conquered Samaria and deported the Israelites to Assyria. He resettled them in Halah, in Gozan by the Habor River, and in the cities of the Medes.[c]
7 This happened because the Israelites had sinned against Yahweh their God, the one who led them out of Egypt, out from under the hand of Egypt's king, Pharaoh. They revered other gods 8 and lived by the customs of the nations whom Yahweh had driven out before the Israelites, and by the customs that the kings of Israel had introduced.[d] 9 The Israelites did in secret[e] things that were not right against Yahweh their God. They built high places for themselves in all their towns, from watchtower to fortified city. 10 They set up for themselves sacred pillars and Asherah poles on every high hill and under every leafy tree. 11 There they burned incense on all the high places, as the nations had done whom Yahweh had carried away before them. They did wicked things that provoked Yahweh to anger. 12 They served idols,[f] although Yahweh had told them, "You must not do this." 13 Yahweh had warned Israel and Judah by means of all his prophets and seers: "Turn from your wicked ways and obey my commands and decrees, following the entire law that I gave your ancestors and delivered to you through my servants the prophets." 14 But they would not listen. They hardened their necks like their ancestors, who had no faith in Yahweh their God. 15 They spurned his statutes, the covenant he cut with their fathers, and the solemn warnings he gave them. They went after empty things and became empty themselves,[g] following the nations around them, though Yahweh had commanded them not to act as those nations did. 16 They abandoned all the commandments of Yahweh their God and made for themselves cast images, two calves. They made an Asherah pole, bowed down to all the host of heaven, and served Baal. 17 They made their sons and daughters pass through the fire. They practiced divination and sought omens, and they sold themselves to do evil in Yahweh's sight,

provoking him to anger. 18 So Yahweh was furious with Israel and put
them out of his sight. No one remained except the tribe of Judah.
19 Even Judah did not keep the commandments of Yahweh their God
but followed the customs Israel had introduced. 20 So Yahweh rejected
all the descendants of Israel. He humbled them and handed them over
to plunderers, until he had thrown them out of his sight. 21 When
he tore Israel from the house of David, they made Jeroboam son of
Nebat king. Jeroboam drove Israel away from following Yahweh and
made them commit a great sin. 22 The Israelites kept on in every sin
Jeroboam had committed and never turned from them, 23 until Yahweh
removed Israel from his presence, just as he had said through all his
servants the prophets. So Israel was exiled from their own land to
Assyria, where they are to this day.
24 From Babylon, Cuthah, Avva, Hamath, and Sepharvaim[h] the Assyr-
ian king brought people and settled them in Samaria's towns where
the Israelites had lived. These newcomers took over Samaria and
made their homes in its towns. 25 When they first settled there, they
did not revere Yahweh, so Yahweh sent lions among them, which
killed some of them. 26 They told the king of Assyria, "The peoples
you deported and resettled in the cities of Samaria do not know the
rules[i] of the god of that land. He has sent lions among them, and
the lions are killing them because they do not know what that god
requires." 27 The king of Assyria then commanded, "Send back one of
the priests you carried away from there. Have him return, settle there,
and instruct the people in what the god of that land requires." 28 So
one of the priests whom they had deported from Samaria came and
lived in Bethel, and he taught them how they should revere Yahweh.
29 But each nation still made its own gods and set them up in the
shrines of the high places that the people of Samaria had made, each
nation in the towns where they lived. 30 Those from Babylon fash-
ioned Succoth-benoth; those from Cuth, Nergal; those from Hamath,
Ashima; 31 The Avvites made Nibhaz and Tartak, and the Sepharvites
burned their children in the fire to Adrammelech and Anammelech,
the gods of Sepharvaim.[j] 32 They also revered Yahweh, and they
appointed from their own number all sorts of people as priests of

the high places, who offered sacrifices for them in the shrines of the high places. 33 So they revered Yahweh but served their own gods, in the manner of the nations from which they had been deported. 34 To this day they keep their former practices. They do not truly revere Yahweh, nor do they follow the statutes, the rules, the law, or the commandment that Yahweh gave to the descendants of Jacob, whom he named Israel.[k] 35 Yahweh had made a covenant with them and charged them, "Do not revere other gods, bow down to them, serve them, or sacrifice to them. 36 Yahweh, who brought you up from the land of Egypt with great power and an outstretched arm, is the one you are to revere. Bow down to him and sacrifice to him. 37 The statutes, the rules, the law, and the commandment that he wrote for you, you must always be careful to do. Do not revere other gods. 38 Never forget the covenant I cut with you, and revere no other gods. 39 Instead, revere Yahweh your God, and he will rescue you from the hand of all your enemies." 40 But they would not listen, and they kept on with their former practices. 41 So these nations revered Yahweh and also served their carved images. Their children and grandchildren do as their ancestors did, to this day.

Notes

- a (17:3) Shalmaneser V reigned in Assyria about 727–722 BC.
- b (17:4) So may be the name of a pharaoh, perhaps Osorkon IV, or a place name, Sais, in the Nile delta.
- c (17:6) The Septuagint reads "the mountains of the Medes."
- d (17:8) The Hebrew of this clause is awkward; it may mean "and of the kings of Israel, which they practiced."
- e (17:9) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; it may mean "ascribed things falsely to."
- f (17:12) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous term, perhaps "dung pellets."
- g (17:15) Hebrew hebel, "vapor" or "breath," a play on the idea of worthlessness.
- h (17:24) These were cities in Mesopotamia and Syria.
- i (17:26) Hebrew mishpat, here "custom" or "required rites." Likewise in verses 27, 33, 34, and 40.
- j (17:31) The names in verses 30–31 refer to deities whose identities are largely uncertain. Nergal was a Mesopotamian god of the underworld.
- k (17:34) Verse 34 appears to contradict verses 32–33; it may mean that these people did not worship Yahweh in the way the law required. Jacob was renamed Israel in Genesis 32:28.

Chapter 18

1 In the third year of Hoshea son of Elah king of Israel, Hezekiah
son of Ahaz king of Judah began to reign. 2 He was twenty-five
years old when he became king, and he reigned twenty-nine years
in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Abi[a] daughter of Zechariah. 3
He did what was right in Yahweh's eyes, just as his ancestor David
had done in everything. 4 He removed the high places, smashed the
sacred pillars, and cut down the Asherah pole. He broke into pieces
the bronze serpent that Moses had made, for up to then the Israelites
had kept offering incense to it. People called it Nehushtan.[b] 5 Hezekiah
trusted in Yahweh the God of Israel. Among all the kings of Judah,
none was like him, whether after him or before him. 6 He held fast
to Yahweh and never stopped following him. He kept the command-
ments Yahweh had given Moses. 7 Yahweh was with him, and he
succeeded in whatever he undertook. He rebelled against the king of
Assyria and would not serve him. 8 He struck down the Philistines all
the way to Gaza and its borders, from lookout tower to walled town.
9 In the fourth year of King Hezekiah, the seventh of Hoshea son
of Elah king of Israel, Shalmaneser king of Assyria came up against
Samaria and besieged it. 10 At the end of three years they captured it.
In Hezekiah's sixth year, which was the ninth year of Hoshea king of
Israel, Samaria fell. 11 The king of Assyria took the Israelites away to
Assyria. He resettled them in Halah, in Gozan by the Habor River, and
in the cities of the Medes, 12 because they had not obeyed the voice
of Yahweh their God but had broken his covenant, all that Moses
the servant of Yahweh had commanded. They would neither listen
nor obey.
13 In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah, Sennacherib[c] king of
Assyria came up against all the fortified towns of Judah and captured
them. 14 Hezekiah king of Judah sent word to the king of Assyria at
Lachish: "I have sinned. Pull back from me, and I will bear any burden
you lay on me." So Assyria's king imposed on Hezekiah king of Judah
about 11 tons of silver and about 1 ton of gold.[d] 15 Hezekiah gave
him all the silver found in Yahweh's house and in the treasuries of
the king's palace. 16 At that time Hezekiah stripped the gold from the

doors of Yahweh's temple and from the doorposts that he, Hezekiah king of Judah, had overlaid, and gave it to the king of Assyria.
17 From Lachish the Assyrian king sent his Tartan, Rab-saris, and Rabshakeh[e] with a large army to King Hezekiah at Jerusalem. They went up and came to Jerusalem. When they arrived, they took their stand by the channel of the upper pool, which is on the road to the Washer's Field. 18 When they called for the king, out to meet them came Eliakim son of Hilkiah, who was over the household, Shebnah the secretary, and Joah son of Asaph the recorder. 19 The Rabshakeh told them, "Tell Hezekiah that this is what the great king, the king of Assyria, says: What is the basis for your confidence? 20 You say you have strategy and strength for war, but these are empty words. On whom are you now relying, that you have rebelled against me? 21 Look, you are leaning on Egypt, a cracked reed for a walking stick, which will stab into the palm of whoever puts weight on it. Such is Egypt's king Pharaoh to everyone who trusts him. 22 But if you tell me, "We are relying on Yahweh our God," is he not the one whose high places and altars Hezekiah has removed, telling Judah and Jerusalem, "You must worship before this altar in Jerusalem"? 23 Now then, make a wager with my master the king of Assyria: I will give you two thousand horses, if you can put riders on them! 24 How could you possibly repel even one governor, the lowest-ranking of my master's officials, when you are depending on Egypt for chariots and cavalry? 25 Besides, is it without Yahweh that I have come up against this place to destroy it? Yahweh himself told me, Go up against this land and destroy it.' "
26 Then Eliakim son of Hilkiah, Shebnah, and Joah said to the Rabshakeh, "Kindly use Aramaic with your servants, since we know that language. Do not address us in Hebrew[f] while the people on the wall can hear." 27 But the Rabshakeh replied, "Was it to your master and you alone that my master sent me to say these things? Was it not to the men on the wall, who along with you will be eating their own excrement and drinking their own urine?"[g] 28 Then the Rabshakeh stood and called out loudly in Hebrew: "Hear the word of the great king, the king of Assyria! 29 The king says this: 'Do not let Hezekiah

fool you; he cannot save you from his hand. 30 Do not let Hezekiah convince you to trust in Yahweh when he says, 'Yahweh will certainly save us; this city will not be handed over to the king of Assyria.' 31 Pay no attention to Hezekiah. This is what the king of Assyria says: 'Make a peace agreement with me[h] and surrender to me. Then every one of you will eat the fruit of his own vine and fig tree and drink the water of his own well, 32 until I arrive and carry you off to a land just like yours, a land of grain and new wine, of bread and vineyards, of olive oil and honey, so that you will live and not die.' Do not let Hezekiah mislead you by claiming, 'Yahweh will save us.' 33 Has any of the gods of the nations ever rescued his land from the hand of the king of Assyria? 34 Where are the gods of Hamath and Arpad? Where are the gods of Sepharvaim, Hena, and Ivvah? Did they rescue Samaria from my hand? 35 Which of the gods of any country has delivered it from my power? So how can Yahweh deliver Jerusalem from my power?" 36 But the people kept silent and did not answer him a word, for the king's command was, "Do not answer him." 37 Then Eliakim son of Hilkiah, who was over the household, Shebna the secretary, and Joah son of Asaph the recorder came to Hezekiah with their clothes torn and reported to him what the Rabshakeh had said.

Notes

- a (18:2) Abi is a short form of Abijah, "Yahweh is my father" (2 Chronicles 29:1).
- b (18:4) Nehushtan sounds like Hebrew nehosheth, "bronze," and nahash, "serpent." Compare Numbers 21:8–9.
- c (18:13) Sennacherib reigned in Assyria 705–681 BC; his campaign against Judah was in 701 BC.
- d (18:14) Hebrew "three hundred talents of silver and thirty talents of gold." A talent weighed about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so about 10,200 and 1,020 kilograms.
- e (18:17) These are Assyrian titles: Tartan, "commander in chief"; Rab-saris, "chief officer"; Rabshakeh, "chief cupbearer" or field commander.
- f (18:26) Hebrew "in Judean."
- g (18:27) So the Qere; the Ketiv uses cruder words.
- h (18:31) Hebrew "Make a blessing with me."

Chapter 19

1 When King Hezekiah heard this, he tore his clothes, covered himself with sackcloth, and went into Yahweh's house. 2 Eliakim, who was

over the household, Shebna the scribe, and the elders among the priests, dressed in sackcloth, were sent by him to the prophet Isaiah[a] son of Amoz. 3 They told him, "Hezekiah says this: 'This day is one of anguish, reproof, and humiliation. The babies are at the mouth of the womb, and there is no strength to bring them out. 4 Perhaps Yahweh your God has heard all the words of the Rabshakeh, sent by his master the king of Assyria to insult the living God, and will rebuke him for the words Yahweh your God has heard. So pray for the remnant of our people who remain.' "

5 When King Hezekiah's servants came to Isaiah, 6 Isaiah told them, "Say to your master, 'Yahweh says this: Do not be frightened by what you have heard, the words with which the lackeys of the king of Assyria have insulted me. 7 I am about to put a spirit in him, so that he will hear a rumor and go back to his own land, and I will make him fall by the sword in his own land.' "

8 The Rabshakeh went back and found the king of Assyria fighting against Libnah, for he had heard that the king had moved on from Lachish. 9 Then Sennacherib received word about Tirhakah,[b] king of Cush:[c] "He has come out to fight you." Once more he sent messengers to Hezekiah, saying: 10 "Say this to Hezekiah king of Judah: 'Your God, in whom you trust, is fooling you when he says Jerusalem will never fall into the Assyrian king's grip. Do not listen. 11 You have surely heard what the kings of Assyria have done to all the lands, devoting them to destruction. Will you then be rescued? 12 Did the gods of the nations rescue those whom my predecessors destroyed: Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, and the people of Eden who were in Telassar? 13 Where are the king of Hamath, the king of Arpad, and the kings of Sepharvaim, Hena, and Ivvah?' "

14 Hezekiah received the letter from the messengers and read it. Then he went up to Yahweh's house and spread it out before Yahweh. 15 And Hezekiah prayed before Yahweh: "Yahweh, God of Israel, you who sit above the cherubim, you and you only are God of every kingdom on earth. Heaven and earth are your making. 16 Turn your ear, Yahweh, and listen. Open your eyes, Yahweh, and look. Listen to the words that Sennacherib sent to mock the living God. 17 It is true, Yahweh,

that the kings of Assyria have laid waste the nations and their lands.
18 They have cast their gods into the flames and wiped them out, since
those were no gods at all, just wood and stone that people had shaped.
19 Now, Yahweh our God, save us, I pray, from his hand, so that all the
kingdoms of the earth may know that you, Yahweh, alone are God."
20 Isaiah son of Amoz then sent this message to Hezekiah: "This
is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: I have heard your prayer
concerning Sennacherib king of Assyria. 21 This is the word Yahweh
has spoken concerning him: "The virgin daughter Zion holds you
in contempt and laughs you to scorn. Daughter Jerusalem tosses
her head behind your back. 22 Whom have you taunted and reviled?
Whom have you shouted at, looking down your nose so haughtily?
It was Israel's Holy One! 23 Through your messengers you have
mocked the Lord,[d] boasting, 'Riding at the head of my chariot host[e]
I have climbed the heights of the mountains, the farthest reaches of
Lebanon. I cut down its tallest cedars, its choicest junipers. I entered
its most remote lodging place, its densest forest.[f] 24 I dug wells and
drank foreign waters. Under my tramping feet every river of Egypt
ran dry.'[g] 25 Have you not heard? Long ago I planned it. From days of
old I shaped it, and now I have brought it about, that you should turn
fortified cities into heaps of ruins, 26 while their inhabitants, drained
of strength, were dismayed and put to shame. They became like
plants in the field and tender green shoots, like grass on the rooftops,
scorched before it grows up.[h] 27 I know where you stay, where you
go, where you come from, and how you rage against me. 28 Because
you have raged against me and your arrogance has reached my ears,
a ring will go through your nostrils, a bridle between your lips, and
I will lead you home again the way you arrived."
29 "And here, Hezekiah, is your sign: for this year the food will be
whatever sprouts on its own, and next year whatever comes up from
that. But in the third year sow and reap, plant vineyards, and eat their
fruit. 30 The survivors of the house of Judah who are left will again take
root below and bear fruit above. 31 Out of Jerusalem a remnant will
emerge, a band of escapees from Zion's mountain. Yahweh's[i] jealous
passion will accomplish this. 32 Therefore this is what Yahweh says

about the king of Assyria: Into this city he will not come; no arrow of his will fly over it. No shield of his will confront it, or heap up a siege ramp against it. 33 By the road he came, by that same road he will go back, and he will not enter this city, declares Yahweh. 34 I will shield this city to rescue it, for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David."

35 That very night the angel of Yahweh went out and struck down 185,000 in the Assyrian camp. When the survivors[j] got up early in the morning, there were all the dead bodies. 36 So Sennacherib king of Assyria broke camp and went home. He stayed in Nineveh. 37 As he bowed down in the house of Nisroch[k] his god, Adrammelech and Sharezer, his own sons, cut him down with swords and fled to Ararat country.[l] And Esarhaddon[m] his son reigned in his place.

Notes

- a (19:2) Isaiah means "Yahweh is salvation."
- b (19:9) Tirhakah (Taharqa) was a Cushite ruler of Egypt's Twenty-fifth Dynasty, here probably still commander of the army.
- c (19:9) That is, the upper Nile region (modern Sudan).
- d (19:23) Hebrew Adonai.
- e (19:23) So the Qere and the Septuagint; the Ketiv reads "With the chariot of my chariots."
- f (19:23) Hebrew "the forest of its Carmel," that is, its garden-land.
- g (19:24) Hebrew Matsor, a poetic name for Egypt; it can also mean "siege."
- h (19:26) So the Hebrew; Isaiah 37:27 and some ancient witnesses read "like a terraced field." The Hebrew phrase is uncertain.
- i (19:31) The Septuagint reads "of Yahweh of hosts," as in Isaiah 37:32.
- j (19:35) Hebrew "they."
- k (19:37) Nisroch is otherwise unknown; it may be a corruption of Nusku or Marduk.
- l (19:37) Ararat is Urartu, in the region of modern Armenia.
- m (19:37) Esarhaddon reigned in Assyria 681–669 BC.

Chapter 20

1 Around that time Hezekiah fell ill and was close to dying. The prophet Isaiah son of Amoz came to him and said, "Yahweh says this: 'Put your household in order, because you are going to die; you will not get well.' " 2 Hezekiah turned his face toward the wall and prayed to Yahweh: 3 "Yahweh, please call to mind that I have walked in your

presence with loyalty and an undivided heart and have done what is right in your eyes." And Hezekiah broke down in tears.
4 Before Isaiah had got out past the middle courtyard,[a] the word of Yahweh came to him: 5 "Go back and tell Hezekiah, the leader of my people, 'This is what Yahweh, the God of your ancestor David, says: I have listened to your prayer and seen your tears. I am going to heal you. Two days from now you will go up to Yahweh's house. 6 I am adding fifteen years to your life. From the hand of Assyria's king I will deliver both you and this city, and I will defend this city for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David.' " 7 Then Isaiah said, "Bring a lump of pressed figs." They brought it and put it on the boil, and he recovered.
8 Hezekiah had asked Isaiah, "What will be the sign that Yahweh is going to heal me and that I will go up to Yahweh's house the day after tomorrow?" 9 Isaiah answered, "This is your sign from Yahweh that he will do what he has promised: Shall the shadow move forward ten steps[b] or go back ten steps?" 10 Hezekiah said, "It is easy for the shadow to lengthen by ten steps. No, let the shadow turn back ten steps." 11 So the prophet Isaiah called out to Yahweh, and Yahweh brought the shadow back the ten steps it had already gone down on the stairway of Ahaz.
12 At that time the king of Babylon, Berodach-baladan[c] son of Baladan, sent Hezekiah letters and a present, having heard that Hezekiah was sick. 13 Hezekiah welcomed[d] the envoys and showed them his entire storehouse: the silver, the gold, the spices, the fine oil, his armory, and everything in his treasuries. There was nothing in his palace or anywhere in his realm that Hezekiah failed to show them.
14 Then the prophet Isaiah came to King Hezekiah and asked him, "What did those men say, and where did they come from to see you?" Hezekiah replied, "They came from a distant land, from Babylon." 15 Isaiah asked, "What have they seen in your palace?" Hezekiah answered, "They saw everything in my palace. Nothing among my treasures did I keep from them."
16 Then Isaiah said to Hezekiah, "Listen to Yahweh's word: 17 The days are surely coming when all that is in your palace, and all

that your ancestors have accumulated until now, will be taken to Babylon. Nothing will remain, says Yahweh. 18 And some of your own descendants, born from you, will be taken away, and they will serve as eunuchs in the palace of the king of Babylon." 19 Hezekiah said to Isaiah, "The word of Yahweh you have spoken is good." For he was thinking, "Surely, then, my own days will be peaceful and secure."
20 The rest of Hezekiah's history, all his mighty deeds, and how he built the pool and the channel[e] and brought water into the city, are they not recorded in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah?
21 Then Hezekiah lay down with his fathers, and Manasseh[f] his son became king after him.

Notes

- a (20:4) So the Qere and the Septuagint; the Ketiv reads "the middle city."
- b (20:9) Or "degrees"; Hebrew ma'aloth, steps of a stairway used to mark time by the shadow.
- c (20:12) Isaiah 39:1 and the Septuagint read "Merodach-baladan." The name is Babylonian Marduk-apla-iddina, "Marduk has given an heir."
- d (20:13) Hebrew "listened to." The Septuagint and Isaiah 39:2 read "rejoiced over."
- e (20:20) That is, the tunnel cut through rock to bring the Gihon spring's water into the city, known today as Hezekiah's Tunnel.
- f (20:21) Manasseh means "causing to forget."

Chapter 21

1 Manasseh was twelve when he took the throne, and he ruled in Jerusalem fifty-five years. His mother was named Hephzibah.[a] 2 He did what Yahweh considered evil, copying the detestable customs of the nations Yahweh had driven out ahead of the Israelites. 3 He rebuilt the shrines on the high places that his father Hezekiah had torn down. He put up altars to Baal and made an Asherah pole,[b] just as Ahab king of Israel had done, and he bowed down to the whole army of the sky and served them. 4 He built altars inside Yahweh's house, the very place of which Yahweh had said, "In Jerusalem I will put my name." 5 In both courtyards of Yahweh's house he built altars for all the starry host. 6 He made his own son pass through the fire.[c] He practiced fortune-telling and omen reading and appointed people who consulted ghosts and familiar spirits. He did a great deal

of evil in Yahweh's eyes, provoking him to anger. 7 The carved image
of Asherah that he had made he placed in the house about which
Yahweh had told David and his son Solomon, "In this house and in
Jerusalem, which I chose out of all the tribes of Israel, I will set my
name forever. 8 I will never again make Israel's feet wander from the
land I gave their ancestors, provided only that they take care to do
all that I have commanded them, the whole law my servant Moses
laid on them." 9 But they would not listen. Manasseh misled them into
doing more evil than the nations Yahweh had wiped out before the
Israelites.
10 So Yahweh spoke through his servants the prophets: 11 "Manasseh
king of Judah has committed these detestable acts, worse than any-
thing the Amorites before him did, and with his idols[d] he has led
Judah into sin as well. 12 Therefore this is what Yahweh the God of
Israel says: I am bringing such disaster on Jerusalem and Judah that
both ears of everyone who hears of it will ring. 13 I will measure
Jerusalem with the same line I used for Samaria and weigh it with
the same plumb line I used for Ahab's house.[e] I will wipe Jerusalem
clean the way a dish is wiped, turned upside down after the wiping.
14 What is left of my own heritage I will abandon, giving them into
the power of their enemies, to be pillaged and stripped by every foe
they have, 15 because they have done what is evil in my eyes and have
gone on angering me ever since the day their fathers left Egypt, right
up to today."
16 What is more, Manasseh poured out the blood of the innocent in
such quantity that Jerusalem was soaked with it end to end, besides
the sin he led Judah into by doing evil in Yahweh's eyes. 17 The rest of
Manasseh's history, all he did and the sin he committed, is written in
the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah, is it not? 18 Manasseh
died and was buried in the garden of his own house, the garden of
Uzza, and his son Amon[f] succeeded him as king.
19 Amon was twenty-two when he took the throne, and he ruled in
Jerusalem two years. His mother was Meshullemeth,[g] daughter of
Haruz, from Jotbah. 20 He did evil in Yahweh's sight, as his father
Manasseh had done. 21 He followed his father's path in every way,

serving and bowing down to the idols his father had served. 22 He turned his back on Yahweh, his fathers' God, and refused to go in Yahweh's way.
23 Amon's own servants formed a conspiracy and murdered the king inside his house. 24 Then the people of the land put to death everyone who had plotted against King Amon, and they crowned Josiah,[h] Amon's son, to succeed him. 25 The rest of what Amon did is written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah, is it not? 26 He was buried in his tomb in the garden of Uzza, and his son Josiah reigned after him.

Notes

- a (21:1) Hephzibah means "my delight is in her."
- b (21:3) A wooden cult object associated with the goddess Asherah.
- c (21:6) Some ancient witnesses, including the Septuagint, read "his sons." The rite probably refers to child sacrifice.
- d (21:11) The Hebrew word gillulim is a contemptuous term, perhaps "dung pellets."
- e (21:13) Builders' tools, used here as an image of judgment by the same standard applied to Samaria and Ahab's dynasty.
- f (21:18) Amon means "faithful" or "master builder."
- g (21:19) Meshullemeth means "one repaid" or "one at peace."
- h (21:24) Josiah means "Yahweh supports."

Chapter 22

1 Josiah became king at the age of eight and reigned thirty-one years in Jerusalem. His mother was Jedidah,[a] the daughter of Adaiah of Bozkath. 2 He did what was right in Yahweh's eyes and followed every step of his ancestor David, never veering off to right or left.
3 In the eighteenth year of his reign,[b] King Josiah sent Shaphan[c] the secretary, son of Azaliah and grandson of Meshullam, to Yahweh's house. He told him: 4 "Go up to Hilkiah[d] the high priest and have him count out the silver brought into Yahweh's house, which the doorkeepers have gathered from the people. 5 It is to be handed to the men in charge of the work on Yahweh's house, and they are to pay it to the laborers repairing the damage to the building: 6 the carpenters, the builders, and the stonemasons, and to buy timber and cut stone

to restore the house. 7 But no accounting is to be required of them for
the silver given to them, for they work honestly."
8 Hilkiah the high priest told Shaphan the secretary, "I have found
the scroll of the law in Yahweh's house." Hilkiah gave the scroll to
Shaphan, who read it. 9 Then Shaphan the secretary went to the king
and gave him a report: "Your servants have emptied out the silver that
was found in the house and handed it over to the men in charge of the
work on Yahweh's house." 10 Then Shaphan the secretary informed
the king, "There is a scroll that Hilkiah the priest handed to me." And
Shaphan read it aloud in the king's presence.
11 As soon as the king heard what was written in the scroll of the
law, he tore his clothes. 12 He commanded Hilkiah the priest, Ahikam
son of Shaphan, Achbor[e] son of Micaiah, Shaphan the secretary, and
Asaiah the king's servant: 13 "Go and ask Yahweh on my behalf, and
on behalf of the people and all Judah, about what is written in this
scroll that has been found. Yahweh's rage is burning hot against us,
since our fathers never heeded what this scroll says or did all that it
lays down for us."
14 Hilkiah the priest, Ahikam, Achbor, Shaphan, and Asaiah went to
consult the prophetess Huldah,[f] the wife of Shallum son of Tikvah,
son of Harhas, who was in charge of the wardrobe. She lived in the
Second District[g] of Jerusalem, and they talked with her there. 15 and
she said to them, "This is what Yahweh the God of Israel says: Tell
the man who sent you to me, 16 'Yahweh says this: I am about to
bring disaster on this place and on those who live here, everything
written in the scroll the king of Judah has read. 17 Because they have
abandoned me and burned offerings to other gods, angering me with
all the things their hands have made, my fury will blaze against this
place and will not be put out.' 18 But to the king of Judah, who sent
you to inquire of Yahweh, say this: 'Yahweh the God of Israel says
this about the words you have heard: 19 Because your heart was tender
and you humbled yourself before Yahweh when you heard what I
spoke against this place and its inhabitants, that they would become
a horror and a curse, and because you tore your clothes and wept
before me, I in turn have heard you, declares Yahweh. 20 For this reason

I will bring you to rest with your ancestors, and you will be buried in peace. You will not witness any of the disaster that I will bring on this place.' " They carried her reply back to the king.

Notes

- a (22:1) Jedidah means "beloved."
- b (22:3) That is, 622 BC. The Septuagint adds "in the eighth month."
- c (22:3) Shaphan means "rock badger."
- d (22:4) Hilkiah means "Yahweh is my portion."
- e (22:12) Achbor means "mouse."
- f (22:14) Huldah means "mole" or "weasel."
- g (22:14) Hebrew Mishneh, a newer district of Jerusalem, probably on the western hill.

Chapter 23

1 The king then summoned all of the elders of Judah and Jerusalem to meet with him. 2 He went up to Yahweh's house with all the men of Judah, the people of Jerusalem, the priests, the prophets, and all the people, from the least to the greatest. He read aloud to them every word of the Book of the Covenant that had been found in Yahweh's house. 3 The king stood by the pillar and made a covenant in Yahweh's presence to follow Yahweh and to keep his commands, laws, and decrees wholeheartedly, with his entire soul, confirming the words of the covenant written in this book. All the people pledged themselves to the covenant.

4 The king ordered Hilkiah the high priest, the priests of the second rank, and the doorkeepers to remove from Yahweh's temple every object made for Baal, for Asherah, and for all the host of the sky. He burned them outside Jerusalem in the fields of the Kidron and carried their ashes to Bethel. 5 He eliminated the pagan priests[a] whom the kings of Judah had appointed to make offerings of incense at the high places in the cities of Judah and around Jerusalem. He also removed those who burned incense to Baal, to the sun and moon, to the constellations,[b] and to the whole host of heaven. 6 He took the Asherah from Yahweh's house out of Jerusalem to the Kidron Valley and burned it there. He ground it to dust and scattered the dust over the graves of the common people. 7 He tore down the quarters of the

cult prostitutes[c] that were in Yahweh's house, where the women wove coverings[d] for Asherah. 8 Josiah brought all the priests from the cities of Judah and made unclean the high places where they had burned incense, from Geba to Beersheba.[e] He demolished the gate shrines[f] at the entrance of the Gate of Joshua, the city governor, which was on a person's left as he entered the city gate. 9 The priests of the high places did not go up to Yahweh's altar in Jerusalem, but they ate unleavened bread among their fellow priests. 10 Topheth[g] in the Ben-hinnom Valley he made unclean, so that nobody might ever again hand over a son or daughter to Molech by fire. 11 He removed the horses that the kings of Judah had dedicated to the sun at the entrance to Yahweh's house, next to the room of Nathan-melech the official, in the colonnade,[h] and he burned the chariots of the sun. 12 The altars that the kings of Judah had built on the roof by Ahaz's upper room, and the altars Manasseh had built in the two courtyards of Yahweh's house, the king pulled down. He smashed them there[i] and threw their rubble into the Kidron Valley. 13 The king made unclean the high places facing Jerusalem on the east, to the right of the Mount of Ruin,[j] which Solomon king of Israel had built for Ashtoreth the detestable goddess of the Sidonians, for Chemosh the detestable god of Moab, and for Milcom the abomination of the Ammonites. 14 He shattered the sacred pillars, cut down the Asherah poles, and filled their sites with human bones.

15 He also demolished the altar at Bethel, the high place that Jeroboam son of Nebat had made, the one who led Israel into sin. He burned down that high place, ground it into powder, and burned the Asherah pole. 16 As Josiah turned around, he saw the tombs there on the hillside. He sent men to take the bones out of the tombs and burned them on the altar, defiling it, in keeping with the word of Yahweh proclaimed by the man of God who had foretold these things.[k] 17 Then he asked, "What is this marker I see?" The men of the city answered, "It is the grave of the man of God who came from Judah and announced these very things you have done to the altar of Bethel." 18 "Let it be," he said. "Don't let anyone move his bones." So they left his bones alone, together with the bones of the prophet from Samaria.

19 Josiah also removed all the shrines of the high places in the towns
of Samaria that Israel's kings had built, angering Yahweh.[l] He did to
them just what he had done at Bethel. 20 Every priest of those high
places he put to death on their own altars, and on them he burned
the bones of the dead. After that he went back to Jerusalem.
21 The king commanded all the people, "Celebrate the Passover to
Yahweh your God, as it is written in this scroll of the covenant." 22 No
Passover like it had been kept since the days of the judges who led
Israel, nor in all the days of the kings of Israel and the kings of Judah.
23 But in King Josiah's eighteenth year this Passover was celebrated
to Yahweh in Jerusalem.
24 In addition, Josiah swept away those who called up the dead or
consulted spirits, the teraphim,[m] the idols, and every loathsome thing
to be seen across Judah and Jerusalem, in order to fulfill the words of
the law written in the scroll Hilkiah the priest had found in Yahweh's
house. 25 No earlier king could compare with him in turning back to
Yahweh with all his heart, soul, and might in line with the whole law
of Moses, and no later king ever rose to equal him.
26 Even so, Yahweh did not turn from the burning heat of his great
anger, which blazed against Judah because of all that Manasseh had
done to provoke him. 27 Yahweh said, "Judah too I will remove from
my sight as I removed Israel. I will reject this city I chose, Jerusalem,
and the house of which I said, 'My name shall be there.' "
28 The rest of Josiah's history and all he did are recorded in the Book
of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah, are they not? 29 In his days
Pharaoh Neco[n] king of Egypt marched up to the king of Assyria[o]
at the Euphrates River. King Josiah went out to confront him, and
the moment Neco saw him at Megiddo, he put him to death. 30 His
servants carried his body by chariot from Megiddo, brought him to
Jerusalem, and buried him in his own tomb. Then the people of the
land took Jehoahaz[p] son of Josiah, anointed him, and made him king
in his father's place.
31 Jehoahaz was twenty-three when he took the throne, and he ruled
in Jerusalem three months. His mother was Hamutal, daughter of
Jeremiah, from Libnah. 32 He did evil in Yahweh's sight, just as his

fathers had done. 33 Pharaoh Neco imprisoned him at Riblah in the land of Hamath so that he could not rule in Jerusalem,[q] and he placed on the land a fine of about 3¾ tons of silver and about 75 pounds of gold.[r] 34 Eliakim, Josiah's son, was installed by Pharaoh Neco as king to succeed Josiah his father, and Neco gave him the new name Jehoiakim.[s] Jehoahaz he carried off to Egypt, where he died. 35 Jehoiakim paid the silver and gold to Pharaoh, but to meet Pharaoh's demand he had to tax the land. He exacted the silver and gold from the people of the land, from each according to his assessment, to pay Pharaoh Neco.

36 Jehoiakim was twenty-five when he took the throne, and he ruled in Jerusalem eleven years. His mother was Zebidah, daughter of Pedaiah, from Rumah. 37 He did evil in Yahweh's sight, just as his fathers had done.

Notes

- a (23:5) Hebrew kemarim, a term used only for priests of foreign or idolatrous cults.
- b (23:5) Or "the signs of the zodiac"; the Hebrew mazzaloth is uncertain.
- c (23:7) Hebrew qedeshim; the precise role of these cult functionaries is debated.
- d (23:7) Hebrew "houses"; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps woven hangings or garments.
- e (23:8) That is, from the northern to the southern edge of Judah.
- f (23:8) The Hebrew is uncertain; with a small change it may read "the shrines of the goat-demons."
- g (23:10) Topheth probably means "fireplace" or "hearth," deliberately vocalized like boshet, "shame."
- h (23:11) Hebrew parwarim, a word of uncertain meaning.
- i (23:12) Or "He hurried from there"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (23:13) Hebrew Mount of Mashchith, a wordplay on Mishchah, "Anointing," the Mount of Olives.
- k (23:16) The Septuagint adds "when Jeroboam stood by the altar at the festival. And he turned and lifted his eyes to the grave of the man of God," as in 1 Kings 13.
- l (23:19) So the Septuagint; the Hebrew lacks "Yahweh."
- m (23:24) Household gods or images.
- n (23:29) Neco II reigned in Egypt 610–595 BC.
- o (23:29) Or "against the king of Assyria." Neco in fact marched to support Assyria against Babylon in 609 BC.
- p (23:30) Jehoahaz means "Yahweh has grasped." He is also called Shallum (Jeremiah 22:11).
- q (23:33) So the Qere; the Ketiv reads "while he reigned in Jerusalem."

- r (23:33) Hebrew 100 talents of silver and a talent of gold, about 3,400 kg of silver and 34 kg of gold. The Septuagint reads "100 talents of gold."
- s (23:34) Jehoiakim means "Yahweh raises up." Eliakim means "God raises up."

Chapter 24

1 During Jehoiakim's reign Nebuchadnezzar[a] king of Babylon came up
against him, and Jehoiakim became his vassal for three years. Then
he changed course and rebelled against him. 2 Yahweh sent raiding
bands of Chaldeans, Arameans, Moabites, and Ammonites against Je-
hoiakim; he let them loose on Judah to destroy it, in keeping with the
word Yahweh had spoken through his servants the prophets. 3 Surely
this came on Judah at Yahweh's command, to thrust them out of his
sight because of Manasseh's sins, everything he had done, 4 and also
because of the innocent blood he had shed. He had flooded Jerusalem
with innocent blood, and Yahweh was not willing to forgive.
5 The rest of Jehoiakim's history and all he did are written in the Book
of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah, are they not? 6 Jehoiakim
slept with his fathers, and Jehoiachin[b] his son became king after him.
7 The king of Egypt did not march out of his own country again, for
the king of Babylon had seized everything that had belonged to him,
from the Wadi of Egypt[c] to the Euphrates River.
8 Jehoiachin was eighteen when he came to the throne, and he reigned
in Jerusalem three months. His mother was Nehushta,[d] daughter of
Elnathan, from Jerusalem. 9 He did what was evil in the sight of
Yahweh, in every way like his father before him.
10 It was then that the troops of Babylon's king Nebuchadnezzar came
up to Jerusalem and laid siege to the city. 11 Nebuchadnezzar king of
Babylon came to the city while his servants were laying siege to it.
12 Jehoiachin king of Judah gave himself up to the king of Babylon,
along with his mother, his servants, his officials, and his palace
officers. In the eighth year of Nebuchadnezzar's reign,[e] the king
of Babylon took Jehoiachin captive. 13 Just as Yahweh had warned,
Nebuchadnezzar hauled off all the treasures of Yahweh's house and
the palace treasures, and he stripped away the gold from all the
vessels Solomon king of Israel had made for Yahweh's temple. 14 He
exiled all Jerusalem: all the commanders and all the leading warriors,

10,000 captives, along with every craftsman and metalworker.[f] No one
was left except the poorest people of the land. 15 He took Jehoiachin
into exile to Babylon. The king's mother, the king's wives, his court
officers, and the leading men of the land he also led away into exile
from Jerusalem to Babylon. 16 The king of Babylon brought to Babylon
as exiles all the men of valor, 7,000 of them, and 1,000 craftsmen and
metalworkers, all of them strong men fit for war. 17 In Jehoiachin's
place the king of Babylon made his uncle[g] Mattaniah king and
changed his name to Zedekiah.[h]
18 Zedekiah was twenty-one when he came to the throne, and he
reigned in Jerusalem eleven years. His mother was Hamutal,[i] daugh-
ter of Jeremiah, from Libnah. 19 He did what was evil in the sight of
Yahweh, in every way like Jehoiakim before him. 20 Indeed, because
of Yahweh's anger, it came to this in Jerusalem and Judah, until he
flung them away from his presence. And Zedekiah rebelled against
the king of Babylon.

Notes

- a (24:1) The Babylonian name Nabu-kudurri-usur means "Nabu, protect the heir." He reigned 605–562 BC.
- b (24:6) Jehoiachin means "Yahweh establishes." He is also called Jeconiah and Coniah.
- c (24:7) That is, Wadi el-Arish, on Egypt's border with Canaan.
- d (24:8) Nehushta means "bronze."
- e (24:12) That is, 597 BC.
- f (24:14) Or "smith"; the Hebrew masger is uncertain, perhaps "locksmith" or "fortification builder."
- g (24:17) Hebrew "his father's brother." The Septuagint reads "his son."
- h (24:17) Mattaniah means "gift of Yahweh"; Zedekiah means "Yahweh is righteousness."
- i (24:18) So the Qere; the Ketiv reads "Hamital."

Chapter 25

1 So in the ninth year of Zedekiah's reign, on the tenth day of the
tenth month (December–January),[a] Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon
came against Jerusalem with his whole army. He camped outside it
and built siege works all around it. 2 The city stayed under siege until
King Zedekiah's eleventh year. 3 By the ninth day of the fourth month

(June–July)[b] the famine inside the city had become so severe that
the common people had nothing left to eat. 4 Then the city wall was
breached, and all the fighting men fled[c] by night through the gate
between the two walls near the king's garden, though the Chaldeans
were all around the city. The king[d] headed off toward the Arabah.[e] 5
But the Chaldean army chased after the king and caught up with him
on the plains of Jericho, and all his troops deserted him and scattered.
6 They seized the king and brought him up to the king of Babylon at
Riblah, where sentence was passed on him. 7 Zedekiah's sons were
slaughtered while he watched. Then Zedekiah's eyes were put out,
and he was bound in bronze shackles and taken to Babylon.
8 On the seventh day of the fifth month (July–August)[f] (that was
the nineteenth year of King Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon),
Nebuzaradan,[g] commander of the guard and a servant of the king
of Babylon, came to Jerusalem. 9 He set fire to Yahweh's house, the
palace, and every house in Jerusalem; every great house he burned
down. 10 The whole Chaldean army that was with the commander of
the guard tore down the walls surrounding Jerusalem. 11 Nebuzaradan,
commander of the guard, carried into exile the people who remained
in the city, those who had defected to the king of Babylon, and the
rest of the population.[h] 12 But the commander of the guard left some
of the poorest of the land to tend the vineyards and work the fields.
13 The Chaldeans broke up the bronze pillars of Yahweh's house, the
movable stands, and the bronze Sea[i] that were in Yahweh's house,
and they carried the bronze to Babylon. 14 They also took away the
pots, shovels, snuffers, dishes, and all the bronze articles used in the
temple service. 15 The commander of the guard took the firepans and
the sprinkling bowls, whatever was of gold for its gold and whatever
was of silver for its silver. 16 The bronze from the two pillars, the Sea,
and the movable stands that Solomon had made for Yahweh's house
was too much to weigh. 17 Each pillar was 27 feet[j] high, with a bronze
capital on top. The capital stood 4½ feet[k] high, and a latticework with
pomegranates encircled the capital, all of bronze. The second pillar,
with its latticework, was the same.

18 The commander of the guard took Seraiah the chief priest, Zephaniah the second priest, and the three doorkeepers. 19 From the city he took one court official who had command of the fighting men, five members of the king's inner circle[l] still found in the city, the secretary of the army commander,[m] who mustered the people of the land, and sixty men of the people of the land who were found in the city. 20 Nebuzaradan the commander of the guard took them and brought them to the king of Babylon at Riblah. 21 There at Riblah, in the land of Hamath, the king of Babylon had them struck down and put to death. So Judah went into exile, away from its land.

22 Over the people who remained in the land of Judah, those whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had left, he appointed Gedaliah[n] son of Ahikam, son of Shaphan, as governor. 23 The army officers and their men all heard that the king of Babylon had made Gedaliah governor, so they went to Gedaliah at Mizpah. They were Ishmael son of Nethaniah, Johanan son of Kareah, Seraiah son of Tanhumeth the Netophathite, and Jaazaniah son of a Maacathite, along with their men. 24 Gedaliah took an oath to reassure them and their men. "Don't be afraid of serving the Chaldean officials," he said. "Stay in the land, serve the king of Babylon, and all will go well for you." 25 In the seventh month (September–October),[o] however, Ishmael son of Nethaniah, son of Elishama, a member of the royal family, arrived with ten men. They attacked and killed Gedaliah, as well as the Jews and Chaldeans who were with him at Mizpah. 26 At that, the whole population, small and great alike, and the commanders of the troops got up and left for Egypt, fearing what the Chaldeans would do.

27 In the thirty-seventh year after Jehoiachin king of Judah went into exile, in the year Evil-merodach[q] became king of Babylon, he freed[r] Jehoiachin from prison on the twenty-seventh day of the twelfth month (February–March).[p] 28 He spoke kindly to him and gave him a seat of honor above the seats of the other kings who were with him in Babylon. 29 So Jehoiachin changed out of his prison clothes and ate at the king's table every day for the rest of his life. 30 And his upkeep was supplied without fail from the king, a fixed share day by day, for as long as he lived.

Notes

- a (25:1) Hebrew “the tenth month,” later called Tebeth, which fell in December–January; the exact modern dates varied with the lunar calendar. The year is 588 BC.
- b (25:3) Hebrew lacks “fourth”; it is supplied from Jeremiah 52:6. The fourth month, later called Tammuz, fell in June–July. The year is 587 or 586 BC.
- c (25:4) Hebrew lacks “fled”; compare Jeremiah 52:7.
- d (25:4) Hebrew “he.”
- e (25:4) That is, the Jordan Valley.
- f (25:8) Hebrew “the fifth month,” later called Ab, which fell in July–August. Jeremiah 52:12 reads “the tenth day.”
- g (25:8) Nebuzaradan is Babylonian Nabu-zer-iddin, “Nabu has given offspring.”
- h (25:11) Or “the artisans,” reading ha’amon with a slight change (compare Jeremiah 52:15); the Hebrew reads hehamon, “the multitude.”
- i (25:13) That is, the great basin of 1 Kings 7:23–26.
- j (25:17) Hebrew 18 cubits, about 8.1 meters.
- k (25:17) Hebrew 3 cubits, about 1.35 meters. 1 Kings 7:16 and Jeremiah 52:22 give the capital’s height as 5 cubits (7½ feet).
- l (25:19) Hebrew “five men of those who saw the king’s face.” Jeremiah 52:25 reads “seven.”
- m (25:19) Or “the secretary, the commander of the army.”
- n (25:22) Gedaliah means “Yahweh is great.”
- o (25:25) Hebrew “the seventh month,” later called Tishri (the older Ethanim of 1 Kings 8:2), which fell in September–October.
- p (25:27) Hebrew “the twelfth month,” later called Adar, which fell in February–March. Jeremiah 52:31 reads “the twenty-fifth day.” The year is 561 BC.
- q (25:27) Babylonian Amel-Marduk, “man of Marduk.” He reigned 562–560 BC.
- r (25:27) Hebrew “lifted the head of.”

1 Chronicles

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Adam,[a] Seth, Enosh, 2 Kenan,[b] Mahalalel, Jared, 3 Enoch,[c] Methuselah,
Lamech, 4 Noah,[d] Shem, Ham, and Japheth.
5 The sons of Japheth: Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech,
and Tiras.[e] 6 The sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz, Diphath,[f] and Togarmah.
7 The sons of Javan: Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, and Rodanim.[g]
8 The sons of Ham: Cush, Mizraim, Put, and Canaan.[h] 9 The sons of
Cush: Seba, Havilah, Sabta, Raama, and Sabteca. The sons of Raama:
Sheba and Dedan.[i] 10 Cush became the father of Nimrod; he began to
be a mighty one in the earth.[j] 11 Mizraim became the father of Ludim,
Anamim, Lehabim, Naphtuhim,[k] 12 Pathrusim, and Casluhim, from
whom came the Philistines, and Caphtorim.[l] 13 Canaan became the
father of Sidon his firstborn, and Heth,[m] 14 the Jebusites, the Amorites,
and the Girgashites; 15 the Hivites, the Arkites, and the Sinites; 16 the
Arvadites, the Zemarites, and the people of Hamath.[n]
17 Shem had sons named Elam, Asshur, Arpachshad, Lud, and Aram,
as well as Uz, Hul, Gether, and Meshech.[o] 18 Arpachshad became the
father of Shelah, and Shelah became the father of Eber.[p] 19 To Eber
were born two sons: the name of the one was Peleg, for in his days
the earth was divided, and his brother's name was Joktan.[q] 20 Joktan
fathered Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, and Jerah,[r] 21 along with
Hadoram, Uzal, and Diklah,[s] 22 and also Ebal, Abimael, and Sheba,[t] 23
and Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab. All of these were Joktan's sons.[u]
24 Shem, Arpachshad, Shelah, 25 Eber, Peleg, Reu,[v] 26 Serug, Nahor,
Terah,[w] 27 Abram, that is, Abraham.[x]
28 The sons of Abraham: Isaac and Ishmael.[y] 29 Their family records
show that Ishmael's oldest son was Nebaioth, followed by Kedar,
Adbeel, and Mibsam,[z] 30 and then Mishma, Dumah, Massa, Hadad, and
Tema,[aa] 31 and Jetur, Naphish, and Kedemah. Those were Ishmael's

sons.[ab] 32 The sons of Keturah, Abraham's concubine: she bore Zimran,
Jokshan, Medan, Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah. The sons of Jokshan:
Sheba and Dedan.[ac] 33 The sons of Midian: Ephah, Epher, Hanoch,
Abida, and Eldaah. All these were the sons of Keturah.[ad]
34 Abraham became the father of Isaac. The sons of Isaac: Esau and
Israel.[ae] 35 The sons of Esau: Eliphaz, Reuel, Jeush, Jalam, and Korah.[af]
36 The sons of Eliphaz: Teman, Omar, Zephi, Gatam, Kenaz, and of
Timna, Amalek.[ag] 37 The sons of Reuel: Nahath, Zerah, Shammah, and
Mizzah.[ah]
38 The sons of Seir: Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah, Dishon, Ezer, and
Dishan.[ai] 39 The sons of Lotan: Hori and Homam; and Lotan's sister
was Timna.[aj] 40 The sons of Shobal: Alian, Manahath, Ebal, Shephi,
and Onam. The sons of Zibeon: Aiah and Anah.[ak] 41 The son[al] of Anah:
Dishon. The sons of Dishon: Hamran, Eshban, Ithran, and Cheran.[am]
42 The sons of Ezer: Bilhan, Zaavan, and Jaakan. The sons of Dishan:[an]
Uz and Aran.
43 These are the kings who reigned in the land of Edom before any
king reigned over the Israelites: Bela son of Beor, and the name of
his city was Dinhabah.[ao] 44 When Bela died, Jobab son of Zerah of
Bozrah reigned in his place.[ap] 45 When Jobab died, Husham of the land
of the Temanites reigned in his place.[aq] 46 After Husham died, Hadad
son of Bedad took his place as king. He was the one who defeated
Midian in the country of Moab, and his city was named Avith.[ar] 47
When Hadad died, Samlah of Masrekah reigned in his place.[as] 48 When
Samlah died, Shaul from Rehoboth by the River became king in his
place.[at] 49 When Shaul died, Baal-hanan son of Achbor reigned in his
place.[au] 50 After Baal-hanan died, Hadad took his place as king. His city
was named Pai, and his wife was Mehetabel, daughter of Matred and
granddaughter of Me-zahab.[av] 51 And Hadad died. ¶The chiefs of Edom
were: chief Timna, chief Aliah, chief Jetheth,[aw] 52 chief Oholibamah,
chief Elah, chief Pinon,[ax] 53 chief Kenaz, chief Teman, chief Mibzar,[ay] 54
chief Magdiel, chief Iram. These are the chiefs of Edom.[az]

Notes

- a (1:1) Names: Adam, "human being," related to adamah, "ground"; Seth, "appointed" (Genesis 4:25); Enosh, "man, mortal." Verses 1–4 follow Genesis 5.

- b (1:2) Kenan, perhaps "smith" or "possession"; Mahalalel, "praise of God"; Jared, "descent."
- c (1:3) Enoch, "dedicated"; Methuselah, perhaps "man of the spear"; Lamech, meaning uncertain.
- d (1:4) Noah, "rest" (Genesis 5:29); Shem, "name"; Ham, perhaps "hot"; Japheth, perhaps "may he enlarge" (Genesis 9:27).
- e (1:5) These names, which follow Genesis 10, mostly stand for peoples and regions; their meanings are largely unknown. Madai is Media; Javan is Ionia (the Greeks); Tubal and Meshech were peoples of Asia Minor. Gomer, Magog, and Tiras are uncertain.
- f (1:6) So the Hebrew; Genesis 10:3 and some Hebrew manuscripts here read "Riphath" (in Hebrew the letters d and r look alike). Ashkenaz and Togarmah were peoples to the north; meanings uncertain.
- g (1:7) So the Hebrew; Genesis 10:4 reads "Dodanim." Rodanim probably means the people of Rhodes, and Kittim those of Cyprus. Elishah and Tarshish are places in the west; meanings uncertain. The Septuagint (B text) reads "the Citians and Rhodians."
- h (1:8) Cush is the region south of Egypt (Nubia); Mizraim is Egypt; Put is probably Libya; Canaan perhaps means "low land" or "land of purple."
- i (1:9) Peoples and places of Arabia and Africa; meanings uncertain. Sheba, perhaps "oath" or "seven," and Dedan were in Arabia.
- j (1:10) Nimrod perhaps means "let us rebel."
- k (1:11) The Septuagint (B text) lacks verses 11–16 and 17b–23. Ludim, Anamim, Lehabim, and Naphtuhim are peoples (the ending -im is plural); meanings uncertain. Lehabim may be Libyans.
- l (1:12) Pathrusim are the people of Pathros (Upper Egypt); Caphtorim are probably the people of Crete. Casluhim, meaning uncertain. Compare Genesis 10:14, where the order differs slightly.
- m (1:13) Sidon perhaps means "fishing place"; Heth is the ancestor of the Hittites.
- n (1:16) These are peoples of Canaan and Syria. Arkites, Arvadites, and Hamathites are named for the cities Arka, Arvad, and Hamath ("fortress"); Sinites and Zemarites for nearby places; Jebusites for Jebus (Jerusalem). Amorites probably means "westerners." Other meanings uncertain.
- o (1:17) Genesis 10:23 lists Uz, Hul, Gether, and Mash (here Meshech) as sons of Aram; Chronicles lists them with Shem's sons. Names: Elam, "highland" (Persia); Asshur, Assyria; Arpachshad, Lud, Uz, Hul, and Gether, uncertain; Aram, perhaps "high," the ancestor of the Arameans (Syrians).
- p (1:18) Shelah, "sprout" or "sending"; Eber, "region beyond," perhaps linked to the word "Hebrew."
- q (1:19) Peleg means "division"; Joktan, perhaps "small."
- r (1:20) Almodad, Sheleph, uncertain; Hazarmaveth, "court of death" (Hadramaut in southern Arabia); Jerah, "moon."

- s (1:21) Hadoram, perhaps “Hadad is exalted”; Uzal, uncertain; Diklah, “palm grove.”
- t (1:22) So the Hebrew; Genesis 10:28 reads “Obal.” Ebal, uncertain; Abimael, “my father is God”; Sheba, see verse 9.
- u (1:23) Ophir, a land famous for gold; Havilah, perhaps “sandy land”; Jobab, uncertain.
- v (1:25) Reu, perhaps “friend.”
- w (1:26) Serug, perhaps “branch”; Nahor, perhaps “snorting”; Terah, uncertain, perhaps related to a word for “moon.”
- x (1:27) Abram means “exalted father,” and Abraham, by sound, “father of a multitude” (Genesis 17:5).
- y (1:28) Isaac means “he laughs”; Ishmael, “God hears.”
- z (1:29) Nebaioth, uncertain; Kedar, “dark”; Adbeel, uncertain; Mibsam, “sweet smell.” These names follow Genesis 25:13–15.
- aa (1:30) Mishma, “hearing”; Dumah, “silence”; Massa, “burden” or “oracle”; Hadad, the name of a storm god; Tema, “desert” (an Arabian oasis).
- ab (1:31) Jetur, uncertain (the Itureans); Naphish, uncertain; Kedemah, “eastward.”
- ac (1:32) Keturah means “incense.” Zimran, perhaps “wild goat” or “song”; Jokshan, uncertain; Medan and Midian, perhaps “strife”; Ishbak, uncertain; Shuah, perhaps “sinking”; Dedan, uncertain.
- ad (1:33) Ephah, “darkness”; Epher, “young deer”; Hanoch, “dedicated” (same as Enoch); Abida, “my father knows”; Eldaah, perhaps “God has called.”
- ae (1:34) Esau, perhaps “hairy” (Genesis 25:25); Israel, “he strives with God” or “God strives” (Genesis 32:28).
- af (1:35) Eliphaz, perhaps “my God is fine gold”; Reuel, “friend of God”; Jeush, “he gathers” or “he helps”; Jalam, perhaps “hidden”; Korah, “bald.”
- ag (1:36) According to Genesis 36:11–12, Timna was the concubine of Eliphaz and the mother of Amalek; the Hebrew here lists Timna and Amalek with the sons. The translation “and of Timna, Amalek” follows some Septuagint manuscripts and Genesis; the Septuagint (B text) lists both as sons. Names: Teman, “south”; Omar, uncertain; Zephi (Genesis 36:11 Zepho), perhaps “watch”; Gatam, Kenaz, uncertain; Timna, perhaps “restrained”; Amalek, uncertain.
- ah (1:37) Nahath, “quietness”; Zerah, “dawning, rising”; Shammah, perhaps “desolation”; Mizzah, uncertain.
- ai (1:38) Seir means “hairy, shaggy” (a wooded hill country). Lotan, perhaps “covering”; Shobal, uncertain; Zibeon, “hyena”; Anah, perhaps “answer”; Dishon and Dishan, “mountain goat”; Ezer, “help.”
- aj (1:39) Hori, ancestor of the Horites (perhaps “cave-dwellers”); Homam (Genesis 36:22 Hemam), uncertain.
- ak (1:40) Alian (Genesis 36:23 Alvan), Manahath (“rest”), Ebal, Shephi (Genesis Shepho), and Onam (“vigorous”); Aiah means “falcon” or “kite.” Several of these meanings are uncertain.

- al (1:41) Hebrew “sons.”
- am (1:41) Hamran (Genesis 36:26 Hemdan, “pleasant”), Eshban, Ithran (“abundance”), and Cheran; meanings mostly uncertain.
- an (1:42) Hebrew “Dishon”; Genesis 36:28 reads “Dishan.” Bilhan, perhaps “modest”; Zaavan, perhaps “disquieted”; Jaakan (Genesis 36:27 Akan), uncertain; Uz and Aran, uncertain.
- ao (1:43) Bela, “devouring”; Beor, perhaps “burning”; Dinhabah, uncertain. Verses 43–54 follow Genesis 36:31–43.
- ap (1:44) Jobab, uncertain; Zerah, see verse 37; Bozrah, “sheepfold” or “fortress.”
- aq (1:45) Husham, perhaps “haste”; the Temanites, “southerners.”
- ar (1:46) Hadad, a storm god’s name; Bedad, perhaps “alone”; Avith, perhaps “ruins.”
- as (1:47) Samlah, “garment”; Masrekah, perhaps “vineyard.”
- at (1:48) Shaul, “asked for”; Rehoboth, “broad places.” The River is probably the Euphrates, or a local river.
- au (1:49) Baal-hanan means “the lord (or Baal) is gracious”; Achbor, “mouse.”
- av (1:50) Genesis 36:39 reads “Hadar” and “Pau” and does not record his death (verse 51). Hadad, see verse 46; Pai, uncertain; Mehetabel, “God does good”; Matred, perhaps “pursuit”; Me-zahab, “waters of gold.”
- aw (1:51) Aliah (Genesis 36:40 Alvah), uncertain; Jetheth, uncertain. Timna, see verse 36.
- ax (1:52) Oholibamah, “tent of the high place”; Elah, “terebinth”; Pinon, uncertain.
- ay (1:53) Mibzar, “fortress”; Kenaz and Teman, see verse 36.
- az (1:54) Magdiel, “gift (or excellence) of God”; Iram, perhaps “city” or “watchful.”

Chapter 2

1 The sons of Israel were Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun,[a] 2 along with Dan, Joseph, Benjamin, Naphtali, Gad, and Asher.[b]

3 The sons of Judah: Er, Onan, and Shelah; these three were born to him by Bath-shua the Canaanite. Er, Judah’s firstborn, was evil in the eyes of Yahweh, and he put him to death.[c] 4 And Tamar his daughter-in-law bore Perez and Zerah to him. All the sons of Judah were five.[d]

5 The sons of Perez: Hezron and Hamul.[e] 6 The sons of Zerah: Zimri, Ethan, Heman, Calcol, and Dara,[f] five in all. 7 The son[g] of Carmi: Achar, who brought trouble on Israel, who acted unfaithfully regarding what was devoted to destruction.[h] 8 The son of Ethan: Azariah.[i]

9 The sons of Hezron who were born to him: Jerahmeel, Ram, and Chelubai.[j] 10 Ram became the father of Amminadab, and Amminadab

became the father of Nahshon, chief of the people of Judah.[k] 11 Nahshon became the father of Salma, and Salma became the father of Boaz.[l] 12 Boaz became the father of Obed, and Obed became the father of Jesse.[m] 13 Jesse became the father of his firstborn Eliab, Abinadab the second, and Shimea the third,[n] 14 Nethanel the fourth, Raddai the fifth,[o] 15 Ozem the sixth, David the seventh.[p] 16 Their sisters were Zeruiah and Abigail. The sons of Zeruiah: Abishai, Joab, and Asahel, three.[q] 17 Abigail bore Amasa, and the father of Amasa was Jether the Ishmaelite.[r]

18 Caleb son of Hezron had children by his wife Azubah, and by Jerioth as well;[s] her sons were Jesher, Shobab, and Ardon.[t] 19 When Azubah died, Caleb took Ephrath, who bore him Hur.[u] 20 Hur became the father of Uri, and Uri became the father of Bezalel.[v]

21 Afterward Hezron went in to the daughter of Machir the father of Gilead, whom he married when he was sixty years old, and she bore him Segub.[w] 22 Segub became the father of Jair, who had twenty-three cities in the land of Gilead.[x] 23 Then Geshur and Aram captured Havvoth-jair from them, along with Kenath and the villages around it, sixty towns in all.[y] All of these were descendants of Machir, the father of Gilead. 24 After the death of Hezron in Caleb-ephrathah, Abijah, Hezron's wife, bore him Ashhur the father of Tekoa.[z]

25 The sons of Jerahmeel, the firstborn of Hezron: Ram his firstborn, Bunah, Oren, Ozem, and Ahijah.[aa] 26 Jerahmeel also had another wife, whose name was Atarah; she was the mother of Onam.[ab] 27 The sons of Ram, the firstborn of Jerahmeel: Maaz, Jamin, and Eker.[ac] 28 The sons of Onam: Shammai and Jada. The sons of Shammai: Nadab and Abishur.[ad] 29 Abishur's wife was named Abihail, and she gave birth to Ahban and Molid.[ae] 30 The sons of Nadab: Seled and Appaim; and Seled died without sons.[af] 31 The son of Appaim: Ishi. The son of Ishi: Sheshan. The son of Sheshan: Ahlai.[ag] 32 And the sons of Jada the brother of Shammai: Jether and Jonathan; Jether died with no sons.[ah] 33 The sons of Jonathan: Peleth and Zaza. These were the descendants of Jerahmeel.[ai] 34 Sheshan had no sons, but daughters. And Sheshan had a servant, an Egyptian, named Jarha.[aj] 35 So Sheshan married his daughter to his servant Jarha, and she gave birth to Attai.[ak] 36

Attai became the father of Nathan, and Nathan became the father of Zabad.[al] 37 Zabad became the father of Ephlal, and Ephlal became the father of Obed.[am] 38 Obed became the father of Jehu, and Jehu became the father of Azariah.[an] 39 Azariah became the father of Helez, and Helez became the father of Eleasah.[ao] 40 Eleasah became the father of Sismai, and Sismai became the father of Shallum.[ap] 41 Shallum became the father of Jekamiah, and Jekamiah became the father of Elishama.[aq] 42 The sons of Caleb the brother of Jerahmeel: Mesha his firstborn, who was the father of Ziph; and the sons of Mareshah the father of Hebron.[ar] 43 The sons of Hebron: Korah, Tappuah, Rekem, and Shema.[as] 44 Shema became the father of Raham the father of Jorkeam, and Rekem became the father of Shammai.[at] 45 The son of Shammai: Maon; and Maon was the father of Beth-zur.[au] 46 Ephah also, Caleb's concubine, bore Haran, Moza, and Gazez; and Haran became the father of Gazez.[av] 47 Jahdai's sons were Regem, Jotham, Geshan, Pelet, Ephah, and Shaaph.[aw] 48 Maacah, Caleb's concubine, bore Sheber and Tirhanah.[ax] 49 She also bore Shaaph the father of Madmannah, Sheva the father of Machbenah and the father of Gibea; and the daughter of Caleb was Achsah.[ay]

50 These were the sons of Caleb. The sons of Hur, Ephrathah's firstborn: Shobal the father of Kiriath-jearim,[az] 51 Salma the father of Bethlehem, and Hareph the father of Beth-gader.[ba] 52 Shobal the father of Kiriath-jearim had sons: Haroeh, half of the Menuhoth.[bb] 53 And the clans of Kiriath-jearim: the Ithrites, the Puthites, the Shumathites, and the Mishraites; from these came the Zorathites and the Eshtaolites.[bc] 54 The sons of Salma: Bethlehem, the Netophathites, Atroth-beth-joab, and half of the Manahathites, the Zorites.[bd] 55 The clans also of the scribes who lived at Jabez: the Tirathites, the Shimeathites, and the Sucathites. These are the Kenites who came from Hammath, the father of the house of Rechab.[be]

Notes

- a (2:1) Reuben, "look, a son"; Simeon, "hearing"; Levi, "attached"; Judah, "praised"; Issachar, "there is reward"; Zebulun, "honor" or "dwelling" (Genesis 29–30).
- b (2:2) Dan, "judge"; Joseph, "may he add"; Benjamin, "son of the right hand"; Naphtali, "my wrestling"; Gad, "good fortune"; Asher, "happy."

- c (2:3) Er, “watchful”; Onan, “vigor”; Shelah, see 1:18; Bath-shua, “daughter of Shua” (Genesis 38:2). Compare Genesis 38:7.
- d (2:4) Tamar, “palm tree”; Perez, “breach”; Zerah, “dawning.”
- e (2:5) Hezron, perhaps “enclosure”; Hamul, “spared.”
- f (2:6) So the Hebrew; some ancient witnesses and 1 Kings 4:31 read “Darda.” Zimri (Joshua 7:1 Zabdi), “my praise” or “my protection”; Ethan, “enduring”; Heman, “faithful”; Calcol, “sustenance”; Dara, uncertain.
- g (2:7) Hebrew “sons.”
- h (2:7) Achar means “trouble” and is a play on Hebrew ‘oker, “troubler”; Joshua 7:1 calls him Achan. Carmi means “my vineyard.”
- i (2:8) Azariah means “Yahweh has helped.”
- j (2:9) Jerahmeel, “may God have compassion”; Ram, “high”; Chelubai, another form of Caleb (verse 18), perhaps “dog.”
- k (2:10) Amminadab, “my kinsman is noble”; Nahshon, perhaps “serpent” or “bronze.”
- l (2:11) Salma, perhaps “garment” (Ruth 4:20–21, Salmah and Salmon); Boaz, uncertain, perhaps “in him is strength.”
- m (2:12) Obed, “servant, worshiper”; Jesse, uncertain, perhaps “Yahweh exists” or “man.”
- n (2:13) Eliab, “my God is father”; Abinadab, “my father is noble”; Shimea, “hearing” (1 Samuel 16:9 Shammah).
- o (2:14) Nethanel, “God has given”; Raddai, perhaps “ruling.”
- p (2:15) First Samuel 16:10–11 and 17:12 say Jesse had eight sons, with David the youngest; Chronicles names seven. Some ancient versions add Elihu (compare 27:18). Ozem, perhaps “strength”; David, “beloved.”
- q (2:16) Zeruiah, perhaps “balm”; Abigail, “my father is joy”; Abishai, “my father is gift”; Joab, “Yahweh is father”; Asahel, “God has made.”
- r (2:17) Second Samuel 17:25 calls him Ithra the Israelite. Amasa, “burden-bearer”; Jether, “abundance.”
- s (2:18) Or “fathered Jerioth by Azubah his wife.” The Hebrew is unclear.
- t (2:18) Caleb, “dog” (or “wholehearted”); Azubah, “forsaken”; Jerioth, “curtains”; Jesher, “uprightness”; Shobab, “returning”; Ardon, uncertain.
- u (2:19) Ephrath, “fruitfulness”; Hur, perhaps “white linen” or “child.”
- v (2:20) Uri, “my light”; Bezalel, “in the shadow (protection) of God” (Exodus 31:2).
- w (2:21) Machir, “sold”; Gilead, perhaps “rugged”; Segub, “exalted.”
- x (2:22) Jair, “he enlightens.”
- y (2:23) Geshur, “bridge”; Aram, the Arameans (Syria); Havvoth-jair, “villages of Jair”; Kenath, “possession.”
- z (2:24) So the Hebrew, which is difficult. The Septuagint reads “after the death of Hezron, Caleb came to Ephrathah”; many scholars suggest the text originally said Caleb took Hezron’s wife. Abijah, “Yahweh is my father”; Ashhur, perhaps “black”; Tekoa, “trumpet blast.”

- aa (2:25) Bunah, “understanding”; Oren, “pine tree”; Ozem, see verse 15; Ahijah, “brother of Yahweh.” The Hebrew may mean that Ahijah was a wife of Jerahmeel.
- ab (2:26) Atarah, “crown”; Onam, “vigorous.”
- ac (2:27) Maaz, “anger”; Jamin, “right hand”; Eker, “root, offspring.”
- ad (2:28) Shammai, perhaps “he heard”; Jada, “he knows”; Nadab, “generous”; Abishur, “my father is a wall.”
- ae (2:29) Abihail, “my father is strength”; Ahban, “brother of the wise”; Molid, “begetter.”
- af (2:30) Seled, “exultation”; Appaim, “nostrils” or “face.”
- ag (2:31) Hebrew “sons” throughout this verse. Ishi, “my salvation”; Sheshan, uncertain, perhaps “lily”; Ahlai, “ah, would that.”
- ah (2:32) Jether, see verse 17; Jonathan, “Yahweh has given.”
- ai (2:33) Peleth, “swiftness”; Zaza, uncertain.
- aj (2:34) Jarha, uncertain.
- ak (2:35) Attai, “timely.”
- al (2:36) Nathan, “he has given”; Zabad, “gift.”
- am (2:37) Ephlal, “judgment”; Obed, see verse 12.
- an (2:38) Jehu, “Yahweh is he”; Azariah, see verse 8.
- ao (2:39) Helez, “strength”; Eleasah, “God has made.”
- ap (2:40) Sismai, uncertain; Shallum, “recompense.”
- aq (2:41) Jekamiah, “may Yahweh raise up”; Elishama, “God has heard.”
- ar (2:42) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult. Mesha, “salvation”; Ziph, perhaps “refining”; Mareshah, “summit”; Hebron, “alliance.” “Father” here may mean the founder or chief of a town.
- as (2:43) Korah, see 1:35; Tappuah, “apple”; Rekem, “variegated”; Shema, “hearing.”
- at (2:44) Raham, “compassion”; Jorkeam, perhaps “the people spread”; Shammai, see verse 28.
- au (2:45) Maon, “dwelling”; Beth-zur, “house of rock.”
- av (2:46) Ephah, see 1:33; Haran, “mountaineer”; Moza, “going forth”; Gazez, “shearer.”
- aw (2:47) Jahdai, perhaps “Yahweh leads”; Regem, “friend”; Jotham, “Yahweh is perfect”; Geshan, uncertain; Pelet, “escape”; Shaaph, uncertain.
- ax (2:48) Maacah, perhaps “oppression”; Sheber, “breaking”; Tirhanah, uncertain.
- ay (2:49) Madmannah, “dunghill”; Sheva, “vanity” or “Yahweh contends”; Machbenah, uncertain; Gibea, “hill”; Achsah, “anklet” (Joshua 15:16–17).
- az (2:50) Ephrathah, see Ephrath, verse 19; Shobal, uncertain; Kiriath-jearim, “city of forests.”
- ba (2:51) Bethlehem, “house of bread”; Hareph, perhaps “plucking”; Beth-gader, “house of the wall.”
- bb (2:52) Or “Reaiah, half of the Manahathites” (compare 4:2 and verse 54). Haroeh, “the seer”; Menuhoth, “resting places.”

- bc (2:53) Ithrites, “of Jether”; Puthites, Shumathites, Mishraites, uncertain; Zorathites and Eshtaolites, from Zorah (“hornets”) and Eshtaol (perhaps “asking”).
- bd (2:54) Netophathites, from Netophah (“dropping”); Atroth-beth-joab, “crowns of the house of Joab”; Manahathites, see verse 52; Zorites, uncertain.
- be (2:55) Or “Tirathites, Shimeathites, and Sucathites,” perhaps meaning “gatekeepers, those who hear, and those who dwell in booths”; the meaning is uncertain. Jabez, “he causes pain” (4:9); Kenites, perhaps “smiths”; Hammath, “hot spring”; Rechab, “rider” (Jeremiah 35).

Chapter 3

1 These were the sons of David born to him at Hebron: Amnon, the
oldest, whose mother was Ahinoam of Jezreel; Daniel, the second,
whose mother was Abigail of Carmel;[a] 2 the third Absalom, the son of
Maacah daughter of Talmai king of Geshur; the fourth Adonijah, the
son of Haggith;[b] 3 the fifth Shephatiah, by Abital; the sixth Ithream, by
Eglah his wife.[c] 4 Six were born to him in Hebron, where he reigned
seven years and six months; and in Jerusalem he reigned thirty-three
years.[d] 5 These sons were born to him at Jerusalem: Shimea, Shobab,
Nathan, and Solomon. These four were born to Bath-shua daughter of
Ammiel;[e] 6 then Ibhar, Elishama, Eliphelet,[f] 7 Nogah, Nepheg, Japhia,[g]
8 Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet, nine.[h] 9 All these were David’s sons,
apart from the sons of his concubines. Their sister was Tamar.[i]
10 Solomon’s son was Rehoboam; Abijah his son, Asa his son,
Jehoshaphat his son,[j] 11 Joram his son, Ahaziah his son, Joash his son,[k]
12 Amaziah his son, Azariah his son, Jotham his son,[l] 13 Ahaz his son,
Hezekiah his son, Manasseh his son,[m] 14 Amon his son, Josiah his son.[n]
15 The sons of Josiah: the firstborn Johanan, the second Jehoiakim,
the third Zedekiah, the fourth Shallum.[o] 16 The sons of Jehoiakim:
Jeconiah his son, Zedekiah his son.[p]
17 The sons of Jeconiah the captive:[q] Shealtiel his son,[r] 18 Malchiram,
Pedaiah, Shenazzar, Jekamiah, Hoshama, and Nedabiah.[s] 19 The sons of
Pedaiah: Zerubbabel and Shimei. The sons of Zerubbabel: Meshullam
and Hananiah, and Shelomith was their sister;[t] 20 and Hashubah, Ohel,
Berechiah, Hasadiah, and Jushab-hesed, five.[u] 21 The sons of Hananiah: Pelatiah and Jeshaiah; the sons of Rephaiah, the sons of Arnan,
the sons of Obadiah, the sons of Shecaniah.[v] 22 The son[w] of Shecaniah:

Shemaiah. And the sons of Shemaiah: Hattush, Igal, Bariah, Neariah, and Shaphat, six.[x] 23 The sons of Neariah: Elioenai, Hizkiah, and Azrikam, three.[y] 24 The sons of Elioenai: Hodaviah, Eliashib, Pelaiah, Akkub, Johanan, Delaiah, and Anani, seven.[z]

Notes

- a (3:1) Second Samuel 3:3 calls the second son Chileab. Amnon, "faithful"; Ahinoam, "my brother is pleasantness"; Jezreel, "God sows"; Daniel, "God is my judge"; Abigail, see 2:16; Carmel, "garden land."
- b (3:2) Absalom, "father of peace"; Maacah, see 2:48; Talmai, perhaps "furrowed"; Geshur, see 2:23; Adonijah, "my lord is Yahweh"; Haggith, "festal."
- c (3:3) Shephatiah, "Yahweh has judged"; Abital, "my father is dew"; Ithream, "remnant of the people"; Eglah, "heifer."
- d (3:4) Compare 2 Samuel 5:4–5.
- e (3:5) Bath-shua, "daughter of Shua" or "daughter of wealth," is Bathsheba, "daughter of an oath" (2 Samuel 11:3), and Ammiel, "my kinsman is God," is Eliam, "my God is kinsman," with the parts reversed. Shimea (2 Samuel 5:14 Shammua), see 2:13; Shobab, see 2:18; Nathan, see 2:36; Solomon, "peaceable."
- f (3:6) Ibhar, "he chooses"; Elishama, see 2:41 (here 2 Samuel 5:15 reads "Elishua," "God is salvation"); Eliphelet, "God is deliverance." This Eliphelet and Nogah (verse 7) are not in 2 Samuel 5:14–16; compare 14:5–6.
- g (3:7) Nogah, "brightness"; Nepheg, "sprout"; Japhia, "he shines."
- h (3:8) Eliada, "God knows." Compare 14:7, Beeliada.
- i (3:9) Tamar, see 2:4 (2 Samuel 13).
- j (3:10) Rehoboam, "the people are enlarged"; Abijah, see 2:24 (1 Kings 15:1 Abijam); Asa, perhaps "healer"; Jehoshaphat, "Yahweh has judged."
- k (3:11) Joram (or Jehoram), "Yahweh is exalted"; Ahaziah, "Yahweh has grasped"; Joash, perhaps "Yahweh has given."
- l (3:12) Amaziah, "Yahweh is mighty"; Azariah, see 2:8 (also called Uzziah, 2 Chronicles 26); Jotham, see 2:47.
- m (3:13) Ahaz, "he has grasped"; Hezekiah, "Yahweh strengthens"; Manasseh, "causing to forget."
- n (3:14) Amon, "faithful" or "master craftsman"; Josiah, "Yahweh supports."
- o (3:15) Johanan, "Yahweh is gracious"; Jehoiakim, "Yahweh raises up"; Zedekiah, "Yahweh is righteousness"; Shallum, see 2:40 (Jehoahaz, 2 Kings 23:30–31; Jeremiah 22:11).
- p (3:16) Jeconiah, "Yahweh establishes" (also Jehoiachin, Coniah). This Zedekiah was apparently a son of Jeconiah; 2 Kings 24:17 calls Zedekiah Jehoiachin's uncle.
- q (3:17) Or "Jeconiah: Assir." The Hebrew word 'assir means "captive," and it may be read as a name.
- r (3:17) Shealtiel, "I asked of God."

- s (3:18) Malchiram, “my king is exalted”; Pedaiah, “Yahweh has ransomed”; Shenazzar, a Babylonian name, perhaps “may Sin protect”; Jekamiah, see 2:41; Hoshama, “Yahweh has heard”; Nedabiah, “Yahweh is generous.”
- t (3:19) Elsewhere Zerubbabel is called the son of Shealtiel (Ezra 3:2; Haggai 1:1); here he is listed as the son of Pedaiah, perhaps Shealtiel’s brother. Zerubbabel, “seed (offspring) of Babylon”; Shimei, “famous”; Meshullam, “repaid” or “friend”; Hananiah, “Yahweh is gracious”; Shelomith, “peaceable.”
- u (3:20) Hashubah, “esteemed”; Ohel, “tent”; Berechiah, “Yahweh blesses”; Hasadiah, “Yahweh is kind”; Jushab-hesed, “kindness is returned.”
- v (3:21) The Hebrew is unclear. The Septuagint has “Rephaiah was his son, then Arnan, then Obadiah, then Shecaniah.” The names mean: Pelatiah, “Yahweh delivers”; Jeshaiah, “Yahweh saves”; Rephaiah, “Yahweh heals”; Arnan, perhaps “agile”; Obadiah, “servant of Yahweh”; Shecaniah, “Yahweh dwells.”
- w (3:22) Hebrew “sons.”
- x (3:22) Only five names are listed; one may have dropped out. Shemaiah, “Yahweh hears”; Hattush, uncertain; Igal, “he redeems”; Bariah, “fugitive”; Neariah, “youth of Yahweh”; Shaphat, “he judges.”
- y (3:23) Elioenai, “toward Yahweh are my eyes”; Hizkiah, a form of Hezekiah; Azrikam, “my help has arisen.”
- z (3:24) Hodaviah, “give thanks to Yahweh”; Eliashib, “God restores”; Pelaiah, “Yahweh is wonderful”; Akkub, “heel” or “protected”; Johanan, see verse 15; Delaiah, “Yahweh has drawn up”; Anani, “my cloud.”

Chapter 4

1 The sons of Judah: Perez, Hezron, Carmi, Hur, and Shobal.[a] 2 Reaiah
the son of Shobal became the father of Jahath, and Jahath became the
father of Ahumai and Lahad. These were the clans of the Zorathites.[b]
3 These were the sons[c] of Etam: Jezreel, Ishma, and Idbash; and the
name of their sister was Hazzelelponi;[d] 4 and Penuel the father of
Gedor, and Ezer the father of Hushah. These were the sons of Hur,
the firstborn of Ephrathah, the father of Bethlehem.[e]
5 Ashhur the father of Tekoa had two wives, Helah and Naarah.[f] 6
Naarah bore him Ahuzzam, Hepher, Temeni, and Haahashtari. These
were the sons of Naarah.[g] 7 The sons of Helah: Zereth, Izhar,[h] and
Ethnan.[i] 8 Koz became the father of Anub, Zobebah, and the clans of
Aharhel the son of Harum.[j]
9 Jabez was more honored than his brothers; and his mother called his
name Jabez, saying, “Because I bore him in pain.”[k] 10 Jabez called out
to the God of Israel, “If only you would truly bless me and extend my

territory! Let your hand be with me, and keep me from harm, so that
I will not be in pain!" And God gave him what he asked for.
11 Chelub the brother of Shuhah became the father of Mehir, who
was the father of Eshton.[l] 12 Eshton became the father of Beth-rapha,
Paseah, and Tehinnah the father of Ir-nahash. These are the men
of Recah.[m] 13 The sons of Kenaz: Othniel and Seraiah. The sons of
Othniel: Hathath[n] and Meonothai.[o] 14 Meonothai became the father
of Ophrah; and Seraiah became the father of Joab the father of Ge-
harashim,[p] for they were craftsmen.[q] 15 The sons of Caleb the son
of Jephunneh: Iru, Elah, and Naam. The son[r] of Elah: Kenaz.[s] 16 The
sons of Jehallelel: Ziph, Ziphah, Tiria, and Asarel.[t] 17 The sons of
Ezrah: Jether, Mered, Epher, and Jalon. And she[u] conceived Miriam,
Shammai, and Ishbah the father of Eshtemoa.[v] 18 And his Judahite wife
bore Jered the father of Gedor, Heber the father of Soco, and Jekuthiel
the father of Zanoah. These are the sons of Bithiah the daughter of
Pharaoh, whom Mered married.[w] 19 The sons of the wife of Hodiah,
the sister of Naham: the father of Keilah the Garmite, and Eshtemoa
the Maacathite.[x] 20 The sons of Shimon: Amnon, Rinnah, Ben-hanan,
and Tilon. The sons of Ishi: Zoheth and Ben-zoheth.[y]
21 The sons of Shelah son of Judah were Er, the founder of Lecah;
Laadah, the founder of Mareshah; and the families of the linen
workers at Beth-ashbea;[z] 22 and Jokim, and the men of Cozeba, and
Joash, and Saraph, who ruled in Moab and returned to Lehem.[aa] (The
records are ancient.) 23 These were the potters and the inhabitants of
Netaim and Gederah;[ab] they lived there with the king in his work.
24 The sons of Simeon: Nemuel, Jamin, Jarib, Zerah, and Shaul;[ac] 25
Shallum his son, Mibsam his son, Mishma his son.[ad] 26 The sons of
Mishma: Hammuel his son, Zaccur his son, Shimei his son.[ae] 27 Shimei
had sixteen sons and six daughters; but his brothers did not have
many children, and their whole clan did not multiply like the people
of Judah. 28 They settled in Beersheba, Moladah, and Hazar-shual,[af] 29
and in Bilhah, Ezem, and Tolad,[ag] 30 and in Bethuel, Hormah, and Zik-
lag,[ah] 31 and in Beth-marcaboth, Hazar-susim, Beth-biri, and Shaaraim.
These were their towns until David became king.[ai] 32 And their villages
were Etam, Ain, Rimmon, Tochen, and Ashan, five cities,[aj] 33 and all

the villages around those towns as far as Baal. These were the places where they lived, and they kept records of their families.[ak]
34 Meshobab, Jamlech, Joshah the son of Amaziah,[al] 35 Joel; Jehu son of Joshibiah, son of Seraiah, son of Asiel;[am] 36 and Elioenai, Jaakobah, Jeshohaiah, Asaiah, Adiel, Jesimiel, and Benaiah;[an] 37 and Ziza son of Shiphi, son of Allon, son of Jedaiah, son of Shimri, son of Shemaiah[ao] — 38 these mentioned by name were chiefs in their clans, and their fathers' houses increased greatly. 39 They went to the entrance of Gedor,[ap] to the east side of the valley, to seek pasture for their flocks, 40 There they found fertile, good pasture, and the land was wide, calm, and undisturbed; the people who had lived there earlier were descendants of Ham. 41 These men, listed by name, arrived in the days of Hezekiah king of Judah. They attacked their tents and the Meunites[aq] who were there, destroyed them completely, as is still the case, and settled in their place, since there was pasture there for their flocks. 42 Five hundred of these Simeonites went to Mount Seir with Pelatiah, Neariah, Rephaiah, and Uzziel, the sons of Ishi, as their leaders.[ar] 43 They struck the rest of the Amalekites who had escaped, and have lived there until this day.

Notes

- a (4:1) Here "sons" means descendants over several generations. Names, see chapter 2; Carmi, see 2:7.
- b (4:2) Reaiah, "Yahweh has seen"; Jahath, perhaps "he snatches up"; Ahumai, uncertain; Lahad, perhaps "oppression." Zorathites, see 2:53.
- c (4:3) So the Septuagint; Hebrew "father."
- d (4:3) Etam, "place of birds of prey"; Jezreel, see 3:1; Ishma, "desolation" or "he hears"; Idbash, "honeyed"; Hazzelelponi, perhaps "give shade, you who turn to me."
- e (4:4) Penuel, "face of God"; Gedor, "wall"; Ezer, see 1:38; Hushah, "haste." Hur and Ephrathah, see 2:19, 50.
- f (4:5) Ashhur and Tekoa, see 2:24; Helah, perhaps "ornament"; Naarah, "girl."
- g (4:6) Ahuzzam, "possession"; Hepher, "well"; Temeni, "southerner"; Haahashtari, "the Ahashtarite," perhaps a clan name.
- h (4:7) So the Hebrew margin (Qere), meaning "he shines"; the written text (Ketiv) reads "Zohar" ("whiteness").
- i (4:7) Zereth, uncertain; Ethnan, "gift" (perhaps "hire").
- j (4:8) Koz, "thorn"; Anub, perhaps "grape"; Zobebah, uncertain; Aharhel, uncertain; Harum, "exalted."

- k (4:9) Jabez (Hebrew ya'bets) sounds like the Hebrew for "pain" ('otseb), with two letters reversed. The Septuagint renders the end of verse 10 as "that you would make me know that you will not grieve me."
- l (4:11) Chelub, "basket" or a form of Caleb; Shuhah, "pit"; Mehir, "price"; Eshton, perhaps "restful."
- m (4:12) The Septuagint reads "the city of Naas, the brother of Eselom the Kenizzite" and "men of Rechab." Beth-rapha, "house of a giant" or "of healing"; Paseah, "limping"; Tehinnah, "supplication"; Ir-nahash, "city of a serpent" (or "of bronze"); Recah, uncertain.
- n (4:13) The Septuagint (B text) gives only Hathath; some Greek manuscripts and the Latin Vulgate add "and Meonothai," and the start of verse 14 seems to assume it.
- o (4:13) Kenaz, see 1:36; Othniel, perhaps "lion of God" or "my strength is God"; Seraiah, "Yahweh is prince"; Hathath, "terror"; Meonothai, "my dwellings."
- p (4:14) Ge-harashim means "valley of craftsmen" (Nehemiah 11:35).
- q (4:14) Ophrah, "fawn"; Joab, see 2:16.
- r (4:15) Hebrew "sons."
- s (4:15) Jephunneh, perhaps "he will be turned"; Iru, uncertain; Elah, see 1:52; Naam, "pleasantness." The Hebrew of the end of the verse reads "and Kenaz"; the sense is uncertain.
- t (4:16) Jehallelel, "he praises God"; Ziph, see 2:42; Ziphah, the feminine form; Tiria, uncertain; Asarel, uncertain, perhaps "God has bound."
- u (4:17) The subject is unclear; the second half of verse 18 ("These are the sons of Bithiah . . .") seems to belong before this clause, making Bithiah the mother.
- v (4:17) Ezrah, "help"; Jether, see 2:17; Mered, "rebellion"; Epher, see 1:33; Jalon, perhaps "lodging"; Miriam, uncertain, perhaps "beloved" or "bitterness"; Shammai, see 2:28; Ishbah, "he praises"; Eshtemoa, "obedience" or "I will make myself heard."
- w (4:18) Or "his wife Jehudijah." Jered, see Jared, 1:2; Gedor, see verse 4; Heber, "companion"; Soco, "branches"; Jekuthiel, perhaps "God will nourish"; Zanoah, perhaps "rejected"; Bithiah, "daughter of Yahweh"; Pharaoh, the title of the king of Egypt, "great house."
- x (4:19) Hodiah, "majesty of Yahweh"; Naham, "consolation"; Keilah, perhaps "fortress"; Garmite, perhaps "bony"; Maacathite, of Maacah (see 2:48).
- y (4:20) Shimon, uncertain; Amnon, see 3:1; Rinnah, "shout of joy"; Ben-hanan, "son of the gracious one"; Tilon, uncertain; Ishi, see 2:31; Zoheth, uncertain; Ben-zoheth, "son of Zoheth."
- z (4:21) Shelah, see 2:3; Er, see 2:3; Lecah, "walking"; Laadah, uncertain; Mareshah, see 2:42; Beth-ashbea, "house of Ashbea," uncertain.
- aa (4:22) Or "who married into Moab and returned to Lehem"; the Hebrew is obscure. The Latin Vulgate takes the names as words. Jokim, "Yahweh raises up"; Cozeba, "deceiving"; Joash, see 3:11; Saraph, "burning"; Lehem, "bread" (perhaps Bethlehem). The Septuagint reads "and he changed their names to Abederin and Athukiim."

- ab (4:23) Or “who lived among plantations and hedges.” Netaim means “plants” and Gederah “sheepfold” or “wall.”
- ac (4:24) Genesis 46:10 and Exodus 6:15 read Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar, and Shaul. Nemuel, perhaps “day of God”; Jamin, see 2:27; Jarib, “he contends”; Zerah, see 1:37; Shaul, see 1:48.
- ad (4:25) Shallum, see 2:40; Mibsam and Mishma, see 1:29–30.
- ae (4:26) Hammuel, perhaps “God is my kinsman” or “heat of God”; Zaccur, “remembered”; Shimei, see 3:19.
- af (4:28) These towns follow Joshua 19:2–8. Beersheba, “well of seven” or “of an oath”; Moladah, “birth”; Hazar-shual, “fox village.”
- ag (4:29) Bilhah (Joshua 19:3 Balah), “faltering”; Ezem, “bone”; Tolad (Joshua 19:4 Eltolad), “birth.”
- ah (4:30) Bethuel (Joshua 19:4 Bethul), perhaps “house of God”; Hormah, “devoted to destruction”; Ziklag, uncertain.
- ai (4:31) Beth-marcaboth, “house of chariots”; Hazar-susim, “village of horses”; Beth-biri (Joshua 19:6 Beth-lebaoth), perhaps “house of my creation”; Shaaraim (Joshua 19:6 Sharuhen), “two gates.”
- aj (4:32) Etam, see verse 3; Ain, “spring”; Rimmon, “pomegranate”; Tochen (Joshua 19:7 Ether), “measure”; Ashan, “smoke.”
- ak (4:33) Baal, “lord, master” (Joshua 19:8 Baalath-beer).
- al (4:34) Meshobab, “restored”; Jamlech, “he makes king”; Joshah, “Yahweh’s gift”; Amaziah, see 3:12.
- am (4:35) Joel, “Yahweh is God”; Jehu, see 2:38; Joshibiah, “Yahweh causes to dwell”; Seraiah, see verse 13; Asiel, “God has made.”
- an (4:36) Elioenai, see 3:23; Jaakobah, a form of Jacob, “heel-holder” or “may he protect”; Jeshohaiah, uncertain; Asaiah, “Yahweh has made”; Adiel, “ornament of God”; Jesimiel, “God establishes”; Benaiah, “Yahweh has built.”
- ao (4:37) Ziza, uncertain; Shiphi, “abundance”; Allon, “oak”; Jedaiah, “Yahweh knows”; Shimri, “my guard”; Shemaiah, see 3:22.
- ap (4:39) The Septuagint reads “Gerara,” that is, Gerar.
- aq (4:41) Hebrew Meʿinim (Qere), a people perhaps related to Maon; the written text could be read “dwellings.” The Septuagint reads “Minaeans.”
- ar (4:42) Pelatiah and Rephaiah, see 3:21; Neariah, see 3:22; Uzziel, “God is my strength”; Ishi, see 2:31.

Chapter 5

1 The sons of Reuben, Israel’s firstborn (he was the firstborn, but because he dishonored his father’s bed, his birthright was given to the sons of Joseph son of Israel, so that he is not recorded in the family records as the firstborn;[a] 2 for Judah prevailed above his brothers, and from him came a prince,[b] yet the right of the firstborn was Joseph’s):

3 the sons of Reuben the firstborn of Israel: Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron,
and Carmi.[c] 4 The sons of Joel: Shemaiah his son, Gog his son, Shimei
his son,[d] 5 Micah his son, Reaiah his son, Baal his son,[e] 6 Beerah his
son, whom Tilgath-pilneser king of Assyria took away captive; he
was prince of the Reubenites.[f] 7 His brothers by their families, when
the genealogy of their generations was reckoned: the chief, Jeiel, and
Zechariah,[g] 8 and Bela son of Azaz, son of Shema, son of Joel. They
settled in Aroer and extended to Nebo and Baal-meon.[h] 9 To the east
they also settled up to the edge of the desert, which borders the
Euphrates River, since their herds had grown large in Gilead. 10 During
Saul's reign they fought the Hagrites and defeated them, and then
they settled in the tents of the Hagrites across the whole eastern side
of Gilead.[i]
11 The sons of Gad lived over against them, in the land of Bashan to
Salecah:[j] 12 Joel the chief, Shapham the second, Janai, and Shaphat
in Bashan.[k] 13 Their relatives, by family: Michael, Meshullam, Sheba,
Jorai, Jacan, Zia, and Eber, seven in all.[l] 14 These were the sons of
Abihail the son of Huri, son of Jaroah, son of Gilead, son of Michael,
son of Jeshishai, son of Jahdo, son of Buz.[m] 15 Ahi the son of Abdiel,
son of Guni, was chief of their fathers' house.[n] 16 They lived in Gilead,
in Bashan and its towns, and in all the pasture lands of Sharon to
their limits.[o] 17 All of these were entered in the family records during
the reigns of Jotham king of Judah and Jeroboam king of Israel.[p]
18 Among the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh
were 44,760 brave soldiers, trained for war, who carried shields and
swords, could shoot the bow, and were ready to go to battle. 19 They
fought with the Hagrites, with Jetur, Naphish, and Nodab.[q] 20 They
were helped in fighting them, and the Hagrites and all their allies
were handed over to them, because during the battle they called out
to God, and he granted their request since they put their trust in him.
21 They took away their animals: of camels fifty thousand, of sheep
two hundred and fifty thousand, of donkeys two thousand, and of
people a hundred thousand.[r] 22 For many fell slain, because the war
was of God. And they lived in their place until the exile.

23 The half-tribe of Manasseh settled in the land, and they grew very
numerous, from Bashan to Baal-hermon, Senir, and Mount Hermon.[s]
24 These were the heads of their family groups: Epher, Ishi, Eliel,
Azriel, Jeremiah, Hodaviah, and Jahdiel. They were brave warriors
and well-known men, each the head of his family.[t] 25 But they broke
faith with the God of their fathers, and prostituted themselves after
the gods of the peoples of the land, whom God had destroyed before
them. 26 So the God of Israel roused the spirit of Pul king of Assyria,
who is also called Tilgath-pilneser king of Assyria, and Tilgath-pil-
neser took the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh
into exile. He brought them to Halah, Habor, Hara, and the River
Gozan, and they are there today.[u]

Notes

- a (5:1) See Genesis 35:22; 49:3–4; 48:5. Reuben, see 2:1.
- b (5:2) Or "a leader." Hebrew nagid.
- c (5:3) Hanoch, see 1:33; Pallu, "distinguished"; Hezron, see 2:5; Carmi, see 2:7.
- d (5:4) Joel, see 4:35; Shemaiah, see 3:22; Gog, uncertain; Shimei, see 3:19. Joel's link to Reuben is not stated.
- e (5:5) Micah, "who is like Yahweh?"; Reaiah, see 4:2; Baal, see 4:33.
- f (5:6) Tilgath-pilneser is the Chronicler's spelling of Tiglath-pileser (2 Kings 15:29), Assyrian Tukulti-apil-Esharra, "my trust is in the son of Esharra." Beerah, "well." He reigned about 745–727 B.C.
- g (5:7) Jeiel, perhaps "God sweeps away" or "God lives"; Zechariah, "Yahweh remembers."
- h (5:8) Bela, see 1:43; Azaz, "strong"; Shema, see 2:43; Aroer, perhaps "juniper"; Nebo, a god's name (Nabu); Baal-meon, "lord of the dwelling."
- i (5:10) The Hagrites (Hebrew Hagri'im) were a people east of the Jordan, perhaps named after Hagar (Genesis 16); the Septuagint reads "sojourners" here (taking the word as "stranger"), and "Agarenes" in verse 19. Saul, see 1:48 (Shaul); Gilead, see 2:21.
- j (5:11) Gad, see 2:2; Bashan, perhaps "fertile plain"; Salecah, uncertain.
- k (5:12) Shapham, perhaps "bold"; Janai, "he answers"; Shaphat, see 3:22.
- l (5:13) Michael, "who is like God?"; Meshullam, see 3:19; Sheba, see 1:9; Jorai, perhaps "Yahweh teaches"; Jacan, perhaps "trouble"; Zia, "motion"; Eber, see 1:18.
- m (5:14) Abihail, see 2:29; Huri, "linen worker"; Jaroah, perhaps "moon"; Jeshishai, "aged"; Jahdo, "his union"; Buz, "contempt."
- n (5:15) Ahi, "my brother"; Abdiel, "servant of God"; Guni, perhaps "painted."
- o (5:16) This Sharon, "plain," is east of the Jordan, not the coastal plain.

- p (5:17) Jotham reigned in Judah about 750–735 B.C., and Jeroboam II in Israel about 793–753 B.C. Jeroboam means “the people contend” or “may the people multiply.”
- q (5:19) Jetur and Naphish, see 1:31; Nodab, “nobility.”
- r (5:21) Hebrew “souls of men.” The Septuagint (B text) reads “five thousand camels.”
- s (5:23) Manasseh, see 3:13; Baal-hermon, “lord of Hermon”; Senir, the Amorite name for Hermon (Deuteronomy 3:9); Hermon, “sacred mountain.”
- t (5:24) Epher, see 1:33; Ishi, see 2:31; Eliel, “my God is God”; Azriel, “my help is God”; Jeremiah, “Yahweh lifts up” or “Yahweh founds”; Hodaviah, see 3:24; Jahdiel, “God makes glad.”
- u (5:26) Or “Pul king of Assyria, and the spirit of Tilgath-pilneser.” Pul (Assyrian Pulu) was the Babylonian throne name of Tiglath-pileser III (compare 2 Kings 15:19, 29). Halah, Habor, and Gozan were in northern Mesopotamia (2 Kings 17:6); Hara, uncertain, is not in Kings.

Chapter 6

1 The sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.[a] 2 The sons of Kohath:
Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.[b] 3 The children of Amram: Aaron,
Moses, and Miriam. The sons of Aaron: Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and
Ithamar.[c] 4 Eleazar became the father of Phinehas, Phinehas became
the father of Abishua,[d] 5 Abishua became the father of Bukki, Bukki
became the father of Uzzi,[e] 6 Uzzi became the father of Zerahiah,
Zerahiah became the father of Meraioth,[f] 7 Meraioth became the
father of Amariah, Amariah became the father of Ahitub,[g] 8 Ahitub
became the father of Zadok, Zadok became the father of Ahimaaz,[h] 9
Ahimaaz became the father of Azariah, Azariah became the father of
Johanan, 10 and Johanan became the father of Azariah, who performed
the priest’s office in the temple that Solomon built in Jerusalem.[i] 11
Azariah became the father of Amariah, Amariah became the father
of Ahitub, 12 Ahitub became the father of Zadok, Zadok became the
father of Shallum, 13 Shallum became the father of Hilkiah, Hilkiah
became the father of Azariah,[j] 14 Azariah fathered Seraiah, and
Seraiah fathered Jehozadak;[k] 15 and Jehozadak went into captivity
when Yahweh carried Judah and Jerusalem away by the hand of
Nebuchadnezzar.[l]
16 The sons of Levi: Gershom, Kohath, and Merari.[m] 17 These are the
names of the sons of Gershom: Libni and Shimei.[n] 18 The sons of

Kohath: Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel. 19 The sons of Merari:
Mahli and Mushi. These are the clans of the Levites according to their
fathers.[o] 20 Of Gershom: Libni his son, Jahath his son, Zimmah his
son,[p] 21 Joah his son, Iddo his son, Zerah his son, Jeatherai his son.[q]
22 The sons of Kohath: Amminadab his son, Korah his son, Assir his
son,[r] 23 Elkanah his son, Ebiasaph his son, Assir his son,[s] 24 Tahath
his son, Uriel his son, Uzziah his son, and Shaul his son.[t] 25 The sons
of Elkanah: Amasai and Ahimoth.[u] 26 Elkanah: the sons of Elkanah:[v]
Zophai his son, Nahath his son,[w] 27 Eliab his son, Jeroham his son,
Elkanah his son.[x] 28 The sons of Samuel: the firstborn Joel,[y] and the
second Abijah.[z] 29 The sons of Merari: Mahli, Libni his son, Shimei
his son, Uzzah his son,[aa] 30 Shimea his son, Haggiah his son, Asaiah
his son.[ab]
31 These are those whom David set over the service of song in the
house of Yahweh, after the ark had a resting place.[ac] 32 They served
with singing in front of the tent of meeting, the tabernacle, until
Solomon built Yahweh's house in Jerusalem, and they carried out
their duties following their assigned order. 33 These are the men who
served, with their sons. Of the sons of the Kohathites: Heman the
singer, the son of Joel, son of Samuel,[ad] 34 son of Elkanah, son of
Jeroham, son of Eliel, son of Toah,[ae] 35 son of Zuph, son of Elkanah,
son of Mahath, son of Amasai,[af] 36 son of Elkanah, son of Joel, son
of Azariah, son of Zephaniah,[ag] 37 son of Tahath, son of Assir, son of
Ebiasaph, son of Korah, 38 son of Izhar, son of Kohath, son of Levi,
son of Israel. 39 And his kinsman Asaph, who stood at his right hand:
Asaph the son of Berechiah, son of Shimea,[ah] 40 son of Michael, son
of Baaseiah, son of Malchijah,[ai] 41 son of Ethni, son of Zerah, son of
Adaiah,[aj] 42 son of Ethan, son of Zimmah, son of Shimei, 43 son of
Jahath, son of Gershom, son of Levi. 44 On the left hand were their
kinsmen the sons of Merari: Ethan the son of Kishi, son of Abdi, son
of Malluch,[ak] 45 son of Hashabiah, son of Amaziah, son of Hilkiah,[al]
46 son of Amzi, son of Bani, son of Shemer,[am] 47 son of Mahli, son of
Mushi, son of Merari, son of Levi. 48 Their kinsmen the Levites were
appointed for all the service of the tabernacle of the house of God.

49 Aaron and his descendants made offerings on the altar for burnt
offerings and on the incense altar, handling all the work in the Most
Holy Place and making atonement for Israel, exactly as Moses the
servant of God had ordered. 50 These are the sons of Aaron: Eleazar
his son, Phinehas his son, Abishua his son, 51 Bukki his son, Uzzi his
son, Zerahiah his son, 52 Meraioth his son, Amariah his son, Ahitub
his son, 53 Zadok his son, Ahimaaz his son.
54 These are their dwelling places according to their encampments
within their borders: to the sons of Aaron of the clans of the
Kohathites, for theirs was the first lot,[an] 55 to them they gave Hebron
in the land of Judah and its pasture lands around it, 56 but the fields
of the city and its villages they gave to Caleb the son of Jephunneh.
57 To the sons of Aaron they gave the cities of refuge: Hebron, Libnah
with its pasture lands, Jattir, Eshtemoa with its pasture lands,[ao] 58 Hilen
with its pasture lands, Debir with its pasture lands,[ap] 59 Ashan with
its pasture lands, and Beth-shemesh with its pasture lands;[aq] 60 and
from the tribe of Benjamin: Geba with its pasturelands, Alemeth and
its pasturelands, and also Anathoth together with its pasturelands.
Altogether their clans received thirteen towns.[ar]
61 The rest of the Kohathites received ten towns by lot from the clans
of the half-tribe of Manasseh.[as] 62 To the sons of Gershom, by their
families, thirteen cities were given from the tribe of Issachar, from
the tribe of Asher, from the tribe of Naphtali, and from the tribe of
Manasseh in Bashan. 63 To the sons of Merari, by their families, twelve
cities were given by lot from the tribe of Reuben, from the tribe of
Gad, and from the tribe of Zebulun. 64 So the Israelites gave the Levites
the cities with their pasture lands. 65 They assigned these towns,
which are listed by name, by lot from the tribes of Judah, Simeon, and
Benjamin.
66 Some of the families of the sons of Kohath had cities of their borders
from the tribe of Ephraim. 67 They gave to them the cities of refuge,
Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim with its pasture lands, and
Gezer with its pasture lands,[at] 68 Jokmeam with its pasture lands, Beth-
horon with its pasture lands,[au] 69 Aijalon with its pasture lands, and
Gath-rimmon with its pasture lands;[av] 70 and from the half-tribe of

Manasseh: Aner with its pasturelands, and also Bileam with its pasturelands. These went to the remaining families of the Kohathites.[aw]
71 The Gershomites received from the clan of the half-tribe of Manasseh: Golan in Bashan with its pasturelands, and also Ashtaroth with its pasturelands;[ax] 72 and out of the tribe of Issachar: Kedesh with its pasture lands, Daberath with its pasture lands,[ay] 73 Ramoth with its pasture lands, and Anem with its pasture lands;[az] 74 out of the tribe of Asher: Mashal with its pasture lands, Abdon with its pasture lands,[ba] 75 Hukok with its pasture lands, and Rehob with its pasture lands;[bb] 76 and out of the tribe of Naphtali: Kedesh in Galilee with its pasture lands, Hammon with its pasture lands, and Kiriathaim with its pasture lands.[bc]
77 To the rest of the Merarites were given out of the tribe of Zebulun: Rimmono with its pasture lands and Tabor with its pasture lands;[bd] 78 and across the Jordan from Jericho, east of the Jordan, from the tribe of Reuben: Bezer in the desert and its pasturelands, and Jahzah and its pasturelands,[be] 79 Kedemoth with its pasture lands, and Mephaath with its pasture lands;[bf] 80 and out of the tribe of Gad: Ramoth in Gilead with its pasture lands, Mahanaim with its pasture lands,[bg] 81 Heshbon with its pasture lands, and Jazer with its pasture lands.[bh]

Notes

- a (6:1) Verses 1–15 are 5:27–41 in Hebrew, and verses 16–81 are 6:1–66. Gershon (also Gershom, verse 16), perhaps "a stranger there" (Exodus 2:22); Kohath, perhaps "assembly"; Merari, "bitter."
- b (6:2) Amram, "exalted people"; Izhar, "shining oil"; Hebron, see 2:42; Uzziel, see 4:42.
- c (6:3) Aaron, uncertain; Moses, "drawn out" (Exodus 2:10), probably also an Egyptian word for "son"; Miriam, see 4:17; Nadab, see 2:28; Abihu, "he is my father"; Eleazar, "God has helped"; Ithamar, perhaps "island of palms."
- d (6:4) Phinehas, an Egyptian name, "the Nubian"; Abishua, "my father is salvation."
- e (6:5) Bukki, perhaps "proved" or a short form of Bukkiah; Uzzi, "my strength."
- f (6:6) Zerahiah, "Yahweh has dawned"; Meraioth, "rebellious."
- g (6:7) Amariah, "Yahweh has said"; Ahitub, "my brother is good."
- h (6:8) Zadok, "righteous"; Ahimaaz, perhaps "my brother is anger" or "brother of counsel."

- i (6:10) This note may belong to the Azariah of verse 9, who was Solomon's priest (1 Kings 4:2). The list here also omits several known priests, such as Jehoiada (2 Kings 11) and Uriah (2 Kings 16:10).
- j (6:13) Hilkiah, "my portion is Yahweh" (2 Kings 22).
- k (6:14) Jehozadak, "Yahweh is righteous"; Seraiah, see 4:13 (2 Kings 25:18).
- l (6:15) Nebuchadnezzar, Babylonian Nabu-kudurri-usur, "O Nabu, protect the heir." The exile was in 586 B.C.
- m (6:16) Verse 16 is 6:1 in Hebrew. Gershom, see verse 1.
- n (6:17) Libni, "white"; Shimei, see 3:19.
- o (6:19) Mahli, "sick" or "shrewd"; Mushi, perhaps "yielding."
- p (6:20) Jahath, see 4:2; Zimmah, "plan, purpose."
- q (6:21) Joah, "Yahweh is brother"; Iddo, perhaps "his witness" or "timely"; Zerah, see 1:37; Jeatherai, uncertain.
- r (6:22) Amminadab, see 2:10; here apparently another name for Izhar (verses 2, 38). Korah, see 1:35; Assir, "prisoner." Compare Exodus 6:21–24, where Assir, Elkanah, and Abiasaph are sons of Korah.
- s (6:23) Elkanah, "God has created"; Ebiasaph (Exodus 6:24 Abiasaph), "my father has gathered."
- t (6:24) Tahath, "beneath" or "substitute"; Uriel, "God is my light"; Uzziah, "Yahweh is my strength"; Shaul, see 1:48.
- u (6:25) Amasai, "burden-bearer"; Ahimoth, "my brother is death" (compare Mahath, verse 35).
- v (6:26) The Hebrew of the opening of this verse is difficult; compare verses 34–35.
- w (6:26) Zophai (verse 35 Zuph), "honeycomb"; Nahath (verse 34 Toah), see 1:37.
- x (6:27) Eliab (verse 34 Eliel), see 2:13; Jeroham, "he is shown compassion." The text may have lost "Samuel his son" (compare verse 28 and 1 Samuel 1:1, 20).
- y (6:28) "Joel" is supplied from verse 33 and 1 Samuel 8:2, as in some ancient versions. Hebrew "the firstborn Vashni," a word that may be read as "and the second." Samuel, perhaps "name of God" or "heard by God" (1 Samuel 1:20).
- z (6:28) The Septuagint (B text) reads "Sani the firstborn, and Abia." Abijah, see 2:24.
- aa (6:29) Uzzah, "strength."
- ab (6:30) Shimea, see 2:13; Haggiah, "feast of Yahweh"; Asaiah, see 4:36.
- ac (6:31) Ark, see 13:3. Second Samuel 6:17.
- ad (6:33) Verse 33 is 6:18 in Hebrew. Heman, see 2:6 (a different man); Joel, see 4:35.
- ae (6:34) Eliel, see 5:24; Toah, "lowly." Compare verses 26–27.
- af (6:35) Zuph, see verse 26; Mahath, "snatching."
- ag (6:36) Azariah, see 2:8; Zephaniah, "Yahweh has hidden."
- ah (6:39) Asaph, "he gathers"; Berechiah, see 3:20; Shimea, see 2:13.
- ai (6:40) Michael, see 5:13; Baaseiah, perhaps "work of Yahweh"; Malchijah, "my king is Yahweh."
- aj (6:41) Ethni, "gift"; Adaiah, "Yahweh has adorned."

- ak (6:44) Ethan, see 2:6 (also called Jeduthun, 16:41; 25:1); Kishi, “snarer” (15:17 Kushaiah); Abdi, “my servant”; Malluch, “counselor” or “king.”
- al (6:45) Hashabiah, “Yahweh has reckoned”; Amaziah, see 3:12; Hilkiah, see verse 13.
- am (6:46) Amzi, “my strength”; Bani, “built”; Shemer, “guard.”
- an (6:54) Verses 54–81 parallel Joshua 21:10–39, with many differences in the names. The Hebrew word for “encampments” can also mean “settlements.”
- ao (6:57) Libnah, “whiteness”; Jattir, “abundance”; Eshtemoa, see 4:17. In Joshua 21:13 only Hebron among these is a city of refuge; the plural here may be general.
- ap (6:58) Hilen (Joshua 21:15 Holon), “sand”; Debir, “back part” or “sanctuary.”
- aq (6:59) Ashan (Joshua 21:16 Ain), see 4:32; Beth-shemesh, “house of the sun.” Joshua 21:16 also lists Juttah.
- ar (6:60) Joshua 21:17–18 includes Gibeon and names Almon for Alemeth. Geba, “hill”; Alemeth, “covering”; Anathoth, plural of the goddess name Anath, “answers.” The thirteen count implies two cities missing from this list.
- as (6:61) Joshua 21:5 reads “out of the clans of the tribe of Ephraim, from the tribe of Dan, and the half-tribe of Manasseh”; the Hebrew here seems to lack the first part.
- at (6:67) Joshua 21:21 names only Shechem as a city of refuge. Shechem, “shoulder”; Ephraim, “doubly fruitful”; Gezer, “portion.”
- au (6:68) Jokmeam (Joshua 21:22 Kibzaim), “the people will be raised up”; Beth-horon, “house of the hollow.”
- av (6:69) Joshua 21:23–24 adds Eltekeh and Gibbethon from Dan. Aijalon, “place of deer”; Gath-rimmon, “winepress of the pomegranate.”
- aw (6:70) Aner (Joshua 21:25 Taanach), uncertain; Bileam (Joshua Gath-rimmon), perhaps a form of Ibleam.
- ax (6:71) Golan, perhaps “circuit”; Ashtaroth (Joshua 21:27 Be-eshterah), named after the goddess Astarte.
- ay (6:72) Kedesh (Joshua 21:28 Kishion), “holy place”; Daberath, “pasture.”
- az (6:73) Ramoth (Joshua 21:29 Jarmuth), “heights”; Anem (Joshua En-gannim), “two springs.”
- ba (6:74) Mashal (Joshua 21:30 Mishal), “entreaty”; Abdon, “servile.”
- bb (6:75) Hukok (Joshua 21:31 Helkath), “cut, engraved”; Rehob, “broad place.”
- bc (6:76) Galilee, “circle, district”; Hammon (Joshua 21:32 Hammoth-dor), “warm”; Kiriathaim (Joshua Kartan), “two cities.”
- bd (6:77) Joshua 21:34–35 lists Jokneam, Kartah, Dimnah, and Nahalal. Rimmono (Joshua 19:13 Rimmon), see 4:32; Tabor, “height.”
- be (6:78) Some Hebrew manuscripts of Joshua lack the parallel (Joshua 21:36–37). Jericho, perhaps “moon city”; Jordan, “descender”; Bezer, “fortress”; Jahzah, perhaps “trampled place.”
- bf (6:79) Kedemoth, “eastern places”; Mephaath, “splendor.”
- bg (6:80) Ramoth, see verse 73; Mahanaim, “two camps” (Genesis 32:2).
- bh (6:81) Heshbon, “reckoning”; Jazer, “he helps.”

Chapter 7

1 The sons of Issachar: Tola, Puah, Jashub, and Shimron, four.[a] 2 Tola's sons were Uzzi, Rephaiah, Jeriel, Jahmai, Ibsam, and Shemuel. They were heads of the families of Tola and brave warriors of their generations. In David's time their number was 22,600.[b] 3 The son[c] of Uzzi: Izrahiah. And the sons of Izrahiah: Michael, Obadiah, Joel, and Isshiah, five, all of them chiefs.[d] 4 With them, by their generations, after their fathers' houses, were bands of the host for battle, thirty-six thousand, because they had many wives and sons. 5 Their kinsmen among all the clans of Issachar were mighty warriors, eighty-seven thousand, all enrolled by genealogy.

6 The sons of Benjamin: Bela, Becher, and Jediael, three.[e] 7 Bela's sons were Ezbon, Uzzi, Uzziel, Jerimoth, and Iri, a total of five. These were family heads and brave warriors, and their family records list 22,034.[f] 8 The sons of Becher: Zemirah, Joash, Eliezer, Elioenai, Omri, Jeremoth, Abijah, Anathoth, and Alemeth. All these were the sons of Becher.[g] 9 Their family records, listed by generation as family heads and brave warriors, show 20,200. 10 The son[h] of Jediael: Bilhan. And the sons of Bilhan: Jeush, Benjamin, Ehud, Chenaanah, Zethan, Tarshish, and Ahishahar.[i] 11 All these were the sons of Jediael according to the heads of their fathers' houses, mighty warriors, seventeen thousand two hundred, able to go out to war. 12 Shuppim also and Huppim were sons of Ir, and Hushim was son[j] of Aher.[k]

13 The sons of Naphtali: Jahziel, Guni, Jezer, and Shallum, sons of Bilhah.[l]

14 Manasseh's descendants: Asriel, whom his Aramean concubine bore, and she also bore Machir, the father of Gilead.[m] 15 Machir found wives for Huppim and Shuppim. His sister's name was Maacah. Another descendant was named Zelophehad, who had only daughters.[n] 16 And Maacah the wife of Machir bore a son, and she called his name Peresh; and the name of his brother was Sheresh, and his sons were Ulam and Rakem.[o] 17 The son[p] of Ulam: Bedan. These were the sons of Gilead the son of Machir, son of Manasseh.[q] 18 And his sister Hammolecheth bore Ishhod, Abiezer, and Mahlah.[r] 19 The sons of Shemida were Ahian, Shechem, Likhi, and Aniam.[s]

20 The sons of Ephraim: Shuthelah, and Bered his son, Tahath his son,
Eleadah his son, Tahath his son,[t] 21 Zabad his son, Shuthelah his son,
and Ezer and Elead, whom the men of Gath who were born in the
land killed, because they came down to take their livestock.[u] 22 And
Ephraim their father mourned many days, and his brothers came to
comfort him. 23 And he went in to his wife, and she conceived and
bore a son, and he called his name Beriah, because disaster had
come upon his house.[v] 24 His daughter Sheerah built Beth-horon, the
lower and the upper, and also Uzzen-sheerah.[w] 25 Rephah was his
son, and Resheph his son, Telah his son, Tahan his son,[x] 26 Ladan his
son, Ammihud his son, Elishama his son,[y] 27 Nun[z] his son, Joshua his
son.[aa] 28 Their lands and settlements included Bethel and its villages,
Naaran to the east, Gezer and its villages to the west, Shechem and
its villages, and Ayyah[ab] and its villages;[ac] 29 and along the borders
of Manasseh's descendants, Beth-shean, Taanach, Megiddo, and Dor,
each with its villages. The descendants of Joseph son of Israel lived
in these towns.[ad]
30 The sons of Asher: Imnah, Ishvah, Ishvi, and Beriah, and Serah their
sister.[ae] 31 The sons of Beriah: Heber and Malchiel, who was the father
of Birzaith.[af] 32 Heber became the father of Japhlet, Shomer, Hotham,
and Shua their sister.[ag] 33 The sons of Japhlet: Pasach, Bimhal, and
Ashvath. These are the sons of Japhlet.[ah] 34 The sons of Shemer:[ai] Ahi,
Rohgah, Jehubbah,[aj] and Aram.[ak] 35 The sons of Helem his brother:
Zophah, Imna, Shelesh, and Amal.[al] 36 The sons of Zophah: Suah,
Harnepher, Shual, Beri, Imrah,[am] 37 Bezer, Hod, Shamma, Shilshah,
Ithran, and Beera.[an] 38 The sons of Jether: Jephunneh, Pispa, and
Ara.[ao] 39 The sons of Ulla: Arah, Hanniel, and Rizia.[ap] 40 All these
were descendants of Asher, heads of fathers' houses, choice mighty
warriors, chiefs of the princes. Their number enrolled by genealogy
for service in war was twenty-six thousand men.

Notes

- a (7:1) Issachar, see 2:1; Tola, "worm" (crimson dye); Puah, perhaps "madder" (a red dye); Jashub, "he returns" (Hebrew written text Jashib); Shimron, "watch."
- b (7:2) Rephaiah, see 3:21; Jeriel, "founded by God"; Jahmai, perhaps "protector"; Ibsam, "fragrant"; Shemuel, the same name as Samuel (6:28).

- c (7:3) Hebrew “sons.”
- d (7:3) Izrahiah, “Yahweh shines”; Michael, see 5:13; Obadiah, see 3:21; Isshiah, “Yahweh lends.” Five includes Izrahiah.
- e (7:6) The lists of Benjamin’s sons differ: compare Genesis 46:21, Numbers 26:38–41, and 8:1–5. Bela, see 1:43; Becher, “young camel”; Jediael, “known by God.”
- f (7:7) Ezbon, uncertain; Uzziel, see 4:42; Jerimoth, “heights”; Iri, “my city” or “watchful.”
- g (7:8) Zemirah, “song”; Joash, see 3:11; Eliezer, “my God is help”; Omri, perhaps “servant of Yahweh” or “life”; Jeremoth, “heights”; Anathoth and Alemeth, see 6:60.
- h (7:10) Hebrew “sons.”
- i (7:10) Bilhan, see 1:42; Jeush, see 1:35; Ehud, perhaps “united”; Chenaanah, “toward Canaan”; Zethan, “olive tree”; Tarshish, see 1:7; Ahishahar, “brother of the dawn.”
- j (7:12) Hebrew “sons.”
- k (7:12) Shuppim and Huppim (compare Genesis 46:21, Muppim and Huppim), “serpents” and “coverings”; Ir, “city” (perhaps Iri, verse 7); Hushim, “hasty ones”; Aher, “another.” The text may be damaged; some scholars think a list for Dan stood here (compare Genesis 46:23, “the son of Dan: Hushim”).
- l (7:13) Genesis 46:24 and Numbers 26:48 read Jahzeel and Shillem. Jahziel, “God apportions”; Guni, see 5:15; Jezer, “form, purpose”; Shallum, see 2:40; Bilhah, “faltering” (Genesis 30:3–8).
- m (7:14) The Hebrew of verses 14–15 is difficult. Asriel, “God has bound”; Aramean, of Aram (Syria). Machir and Gilead, see 2:21.
- n (7:15) Numbers 26:33 and 27:1 make Zelophehad, “shadow of dread” (meaning uncertain), a great-grandson of Machir. Here “his sister” and “the second” have no clear antecedent. Maacah, see 2:48.
- o (7:16) Peresh, “dung” or “separation”; Sheresh, “root”; Ulam, “porch” or “first”; Rakem, see Rekem, 2:43.
- p (7:17) Hebrew “sons.”
- q (7:17) Bedan, perhaps “son of judgment” (compare 1 Samuel 12:11, where some read Abdon or Barak).
- r (7:18) Hammolecheth, “the queen”; Ishhod, “man of majesty”; Abiezer, “my father is help”; Mahlah, “sickness” or “dancer.”
- s (7:19) Shemida, “the name knows”; Ahian, “brotherly”; Shechem, see 6:67; Likhi, “learned”; Aniam, “I am a people.”
- t (7:20) Shuthelah, uncertain; Bered, “hail”; Tahath, see 6:24; Eleadah, “God has adorned.”
- u (7:21) Gath, “winepress,” a Philistine city. Zabad, see 2:36; Ezer, see 1:38; Elead, “God has testified.” The raid seems to come from Ephraim’s own lifetime (verse 22), though the list of descendants is long.
- v (7:23) Beriah sounds like Hebrew beraʿah, “in disaster.”

- w (7:24) Sheerah, “kinswoman”; Beth-horon, see 6:68; Uzzen-sheerah, “ear (point of land) of Sheerah.”
- x (7:25) Rephah, “riches”; Resheph, “flame” (also a god’s name); Telah, “fracture”; Tahan, “camp.”
- y (7:26) Ladan, uncertain; Ammihud, “my kinsman is majesty”; Elishama, see 2:41.
- z (7:27) Hebrew “Non.”
- aa (7:27) Nun, “fish” (or “continuance”); Joshua, “Yahweh is salvation.”
- ab (7:28) So the Leningrad Codex; other Hebrew manuscripts read “Azzah,” that is, Gaza, which is unlikely here.
- ac (7:28) Bethel, “house of God”; Naaran, “youthful”; Gezer, see 6:67; Ayyah, “ruin” (perhaps Ai).
- ad (7:29) Beth-shean, “house of quiet”; Taanach, perhaps “sandy soil”; Megiddo, perhaps “place of troops”; Dor, “dwelling.” Joseph, see 2:2.
- ae (7:30) Compare Genesis 46:17 and Numbers 26:44–46. Asher, see 2:2; Imnah, “good fortune” or “right hand”; Ishvah and Ishvi, “level”; Beriah, see verse 23; Serah, “abundance.”
- af (7:31) Heber, see 4:18; Malchiel, “my king is God”; Birzaith, perhaps “well of olives.”
- ag (7:32) Japhlet, “he delivers”; Shomer (verse 34 Shemer), “guard”; Hotham (verse 35 Helem), “seal”; Shua, see 2:3 (Bath-shua).
- ah (7:33) Pasach, “divider”; Bimhal, “son of circumcision”; Ashvath, uncertain.
- ai (7:34) Hebrew Shamer; see Shomer, verse 32.
- aj (7:34) So the Hebrew margin (Qere); the written text reads “and Hubbah.”
- ak (7:34) Ahi, see 5:15 (or “his brother”); Rohgah, “outcry”; Jehubbah, “hidden”; Aram, see 1:17.
- al (7:35) Helem, “strength” or “hammer”; Zophah, perhaps “jug”; Imna, “he holds back”; Shelesh, “triad”; Amal, “toil.”
- am (7:36) Suah, “sweeping”; Harnepher, an Egyptian name, perhaps “Horus is good”; Shual, “fox”; Beri, “my well”; Imrah, perhaps “he rebels.”
- an (7:37) Bezer, see 6:78; Hod, “majesty”; Shamma, “desolation”; Shilshah, “triad”; Ithran, see 1:41 (perhaps Jether, verse 38); Beera, “well.”
- ao (7:38) Jether, see 2:17; Jephunneh, see 4:15; Pispa and Ara, uncertain.
- ap (7:39) Ulla, “yoke”; Arah, “wayfarer”; Hanniel, “grace of God”; Rizia, “delight.”

Chapter 8

1 Benjamin became the father of Bela his firstborn, of Ashbel the
second, of Aharah the third,[a] 2 Nohah the fourth, and Rapha the
fifth.[b] 3 And Bela had sons: Addar, Gera, Abihud,[c] 4 Abishua, Naaman,
Ahoah,[d] 5 Gera, Shephuphan, and Huram.[e] 6 These are the sons of
Ehud; these are heads of fathers’ houses of those who lived in Geba,
and they were carried away captive to Manahath:[f] 7 and Naaman,

Ahijah, and Gera; he carried them away,[g] and he became the father
of Uzza and Ahihud.[h] 8 And Shaharaim became the father of sons in
the country of Moab after he had sent away Hushim and Baara his
wives.[i] 9 By Hodesh his wife he became the father of Jobab, Zibia,
Mesha, Malcam,[j] 10 Jeuz, Sachia, and Mirmah. These were his sons,
heads of fathers' houses.[k] 11 By Hushim he had became the father of
Abitub and Elpaal.[l] 12 The sons of Elpaal: Eber, Misham, and Shemed,
who built Ono and Lod with its towns,[m] 13 and Beriah and Shema,
who were heads of families among the people of Aijalon and who
drove out the people of Gath;[n] 14 and Ahio, Shashak, and Jeremoth.[o]
15 Zebadiah, Arad, Eder,[p] 16 Michael, Ishpah, and Joha were sons of
Beriah.[q] 17 Zebadiah, Meshullam, Hizki, Heber,[r] 18 Ishmerai, Izliah, and
Jobab were sons of Elpaal.[s] 19 Jakim, Zichri, Zabdi,[t] 20 Elienai, Zillethai,
Eliel,[u] 21 Adaiah, Beraiah, and Shimrath were sons of Shimei.[v] 22 Ishpan,
Eber, and Eliel;[w] 23 Abdon, Zichri, and Hanan;[x] 24 Hananiah, Elam, and
Anthothijah;[y] 25 and Iphdeiah and Penuel[z] were the sons of Shashak.[aa]
26 Shamsherai, Shehariah, Athaliah,[ab] 27 Jaareshiah, Elijah, and Zichri
were sons of Jeroham.[ac] 28 These were heads of fathers' houses through
their generations, chief men; these lived at Jerusalem.
29 In Gibeon lived the father of Gibeon,[ad] and the name of his wife
was Maacah.[ae] 30 and his firstborn son Abdon, and Zur, Kish, Baal,[af]
Nadab,[ag] 31 Gedor, Ahio, and Zecher.[ah] 32 Mikloth became the father
of Shimeah. They also lived with their brothers in Jerusalem, over
against their brothers.[ai]
33 Ner was the father of Kish. Kish was the father of Saul, and Saul had
sons named Jonathan, Malchi-shua, Abinadab, and Esh-baal.[aj] 34 The
son of Jonathan was Merib-baal; and Merib-baal became the father
of Micah.[ak] 35 The sons of Micah: Pithon, Melech, Tarea, and Ahaz.[al]
36 Ahaz became the father of Jehoaddah, and Jehoaddah of Alemeth,
Azmaveth, and Zimri; and Zimri of Moza.[am] 37 Moza became the father
of Binea; Raphah was his son, Eleasah his son, Azel his son.[an] 38 Azel
had six sons named Azrikam, Bocheru, Ishmael, Shearіah, Obadiah,
and Hanan. These were all the sons of Azel.[ao] 39 The sons of Eshek
his brother: Ulam his firstborn, Jeush the second, and Eliphelet the
third.[ap] 40 The sons of Ulam were mighty warriors, archers, and had

many sons and grandsons, one hundred and fifty. All these were of the descendants of Benjamin.

Notes

- a (8:1) Compare 7:6–12. Benjamin, see 2:2; Bela, see 1:43; Ashbel, perhaps "man of Baal"; Aharah, perhaps "after a brother" (Genesis 46:21 Ehi; Numbers 26:38 Ahiram).
- b (8:2) Nohah, "rest"; Rapha, "he has healed" or "giant."
- c (8:3) Addar, "threshing floor" or "glorious" (Numbers 26:40 Ard); Gera, "grain"; Abihud, "my father is majesty." Or "Gera the father of Ehud" (compare verse 6 and Judges 3:15).
- d (8:4) Abishua, see 6:4; Naaman, "pleasantness"; Ahoah, "brotherly."
- e (8:5) Shephuphan, "serpent"; Huram, "noble."
- f (8:6) Ehud, see 7:10; Geba, see 6:60; Manahath, see 1:40.
- g (8:7) Or "Gera, that is, Heglam." The Hebrew word heglam can be read as "he exiled them" or as a name.
- h (8:7) Ahijah, see 2:25; Uzza, "strength"; Ahihud, "brother of majesty."
- i (8:8) Shaharaim, "double dawn"; Moab, perhaps "from father" (Genesis 19:37); Hushim, see 7:12; Baara, perhaps "burning."
- j (8:9) Hodesh, "new moon"; Jobab, see 1:23; Zibia, "gazelle"; Mesha, see 2:42; Malcam, "their king."
- k (8:10) Jeuz, "counselor"; Sachia, uncertain; Mirmah, "deceit."
- l (8:11) Abitub, "my father is good"; Elpaal, "God is maker."
- m (8:12) Eber, see 1:18; Misham, "their cleansing"; Shemed, "destruction"; Ono, "strength"; Lod, later Lydda.
- n (8:13) Beriah, see 7:23; Shema, see 2:43; Aijalon, see 6:69; Gath, see 7:21.
- o (8:14) Or "and their brothers were Shashak and Jeremoth" (so the Septuagint, "and his brothers"). Ahio, "brotherly"; Shashak, uncertain; Jeremoth, see 7:8.
- p (8:15) Zebadiah, "Yahweh has given"; Arad, "wild donkey"; Eder, "flock."
- q (8:16) Michael, see 5:13; Ishpah, "bald"; Joha, perhaps "Yahweh is living."
- r (8:17) Meshullam, see 3:19; Hizki, a short form of Hezekiah; Heber, see 4:18.
- s (8:18) Ishmerai, "Yahweh keeps"; Izliah, "Yahweh draws out"; Jobab, see 1:23.
- t (8:19) Jakim, "he raises up"; Zichri, "my remembrance"; Zabdi, "my gift."
- u (8:20) Elienai, short for Elioenai (3:23); Zillethai, "shadow"; Eliel, see 5:24.
- v (8:21) Adaiah, see 6:41; Beraiah, "Yahweh has created"; Shimrath, "guarding"; Shimei, see 3:19.
- w (8:22) Ishpan, "he hides"; Eliel, see 5:24.
- x (8:23) Abdon, see 6:74; Hanan, "gracious."
- y (8:24) Hananiah, see 3:19; Elam, see 1:17; Anthothijah, "of Anathoth" (6:60).
- z (8:25) Hebrew Penuel; some read "Peniel." See 4:4.
- aa (8:25) Iphdeiah, "Yahweh redeems."

- ab (8:26) Shamsherai, uncertain; Shehariah, “Yahweh is dawn”; Athaliah, “Yahweh is exalted.”
- ac (8:27) Jaareshiah, uncertain; Elijah, “my God is Yahweh”; Jeroham, see 6:27.
- ad (8:29) Verses 29–38 are repeated in 9:35–44, which names this father of Gibeon as Jeiel. Gibeon, “hill city.”
- ae (8:29) Maacah, see 2:48.
- af (8:30) The Septuagint (after Nadab) and 9:36 add “Ner.”
- ag (8:30) Zur, “rock”; Kish, perhaps “bow” or “gift”; Baal, see 4:33; Nadab, see 2:28.
- ah (8:31) Gedor, see 4:4; Ahio, see verse 14; Zecher, “memorial” (9:37 Zechariah).
- ai (8:32) Mikloth, “staffs”; Shimeah (9:38 Shimeam), see Shimea, 2:13.
- aj (8:33) First Samuel 14:49 lists Saul’s sons as Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malchi-shua; 31:2 adds Abinadab. Esh-baal, “man of Baal” (Baal meaning “lord”), is called Ish-bosheth, “man of shame,” in 2 Samuel 2:8; later scribes replaced “Baal” with bosheth, “shame.” Ner, “lamp”; Saul, see 5:10; Jonathan, see 2:32; Malchi-shua, “my king is salvation”; Abinadab, see 2:13. The Septuagint (B text) reads “Asabal.”
- ak (8:34) Merib-baal, perhaps “Baal contends” or “hero of Baal,” is called Mephi-bosheth, “from the mouth of shame,” in 2 Samuel 4:4 and 9:6. Micah, see 5:5 (2 Samuel 9:12, Mica).
- al (8:35) Pithon, uncertain; Melech, “king”; Tarea (9:41 Tahrea), uncertain; Ahaz, see 3:13.
- am (8:36) Jehoaddah (9:42 Jarah), “Yahweh has adorned”; Alemeth, see 6:60; Azmaveth, “death is strong”; Zimri, see 2:6; Moza, see 2:46.
- an (8:37) Binea, uncertain; Raphah (9:43 Rephaiah), see Rapha, verse 2; Eleasah, see 2:39; Azel, “noble.”
- ao (8:38) Azrikam, see 3:23; Bocheru, “firstborn” (or read “his firstborn”); Ishmael, see 1:28; Shearіah, “Yahweh has esteemed”; Obadiah, see 3:21; Hanan, see verse 23.
- ap (8:39) Eshek, “oppression”; Ulam, see 7:16; Jeush, see 1:35; Eliphelet, see 3:6.

Chapter 9

1 So all Israel was reckoned by genealogies, and see, they are written
in the Book of the Kings of Israel. Judah was carried away captive to
Babylon for their unfaithfulness.[a]
2 Now the first inhabitants who lived again in their possessions
in their cities were Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the temple
servants.[b] 3 Some of the people of Judah, of Benjamin, and of Ephraim
and Manasseh lived in Jerusalem:[c] 4 Uthai son of Ammihud, son of
Omri, son of Imri, son of Bani, a descendant of Perez son of Judah.[d]
5 Of the Shilonites: Asaiah the firstborn, and his sons.[e] 6 From the
descendants of Zerah: Jeuel and his relatives, 690 in all.[f] 7 Of the sons
of Benjamin: Sallu the son of Meshullam, son of Hodaviah, son of

Hassenuah,[g] 8 Ibneiah the son of Jeroham, Elah the son of Uzzi, son
of Michri, and Meshullam the son of Shephatiah, son of Reuel, son
of Ibnijah;[h] 9 and their kinsmen according to their generations, nine
hundred and fifty-six. All these men were heads of fathers' houses
according to their fathers' houses.
10 Of the priests: Jedaiah, Jehoiarib, Jachin,[i] 11 and Azariah son of
Hilkiah, son of Meshullam, son of Zadok, son of Meraioth, son of
Ahitub, the official in charge of God's house;[j] 12 and Adaiah the son
of Jeroham, son of Pashhur, son of Malchijah, and Maasai the son of
Adiel, son of Jahzerah, son of Meshullam, son of Meshillemith, son
of Immer;[k] 13 and their relatives, family heads, 1,760 in all, who were
very capable men for the work of serving in God's house.
14 Of the Levites: Shemaiah the son of Hasshub, son of Azrikam, son
of Hashabiah, of the sons of Merari;[l] 15 and Bakbakkar, Heresh, Galal,
and Mattaniah the son of Mica, son of Zichri, son of Asaph;[m] 16 and
Obadiah the son of Shemaiah, son of Galal, son of Jeduthun, and
Berechiah the son of Asa, son of Elkanah, who lived in the villages of
the Netophathites.[n]
17 The gatekeepers: Shallum, Akkub, Talmon, Ahiman, and their
brothers; Shallum was the chief,[o] 18 who until then had waited in the
king's gate eastward. They were gatekeepers for the camp of the sons
of Levi. 19 Shallum the son of Kore, son of Ebiasaph, son of Korah, and
his brothers of his father's house, the Korahites, were over the work
of the service, keepers of the thresholds of the tent; and their fathers
had been over the camp of Yahweh, keepers of the entry.[p] 20 And
Phinehas the son of Eleazar was chief over them in time past; Yahweh
was with him. 21 Zechariah son of Meshelemiah was the gatekeeper
at the entrance of the tent of meeting.[q] 22 The total number chosen to
be gatekeepers at the thresholds was 212. They were listed by family
records in their villages. David and Samuel the seer had appointed
them to their trusted positions. 23 So they and their children had the
oversight of the gates of the house of Yahweh, the house of the tent,
by watches. 24 On the four sides were the gatekeepers, toward the east,
west, north, and south. 25 And their kinsmen in their villages were
to come in every seven days, from time to time, to be with them; 26

for the four chief gatekeepers, who were Levites, were in an office of trust, and they were in charge of the chambers and the treasuries of the house of God. 27 They stayed the night around God's house, since guarding it was their responsibility, and they had to open it each morning.
28 Some of them had charge of the vessels of service; for by count they were brought in, and by count they were taken out. 29 Others were appointed over the furnishings and over all the holy vessels, and over the fine flour, the wine, the oil, the frankincense, and the spices. 30 And some of the sons of the priests mixed the ointment of the spices. 31 Mattithiah, one of the Levites, the firstborn of Shallum the Korahite, was in charge by trust of making the flat cakes.[r] 32 And some of their kinsmen of the Kohathites were in charge of the showbread, to prepare it every Sabbath.[s] 33 These were the singers, family heads of the Levites. They stayed in rooms of the temple and had no other duties, because they were on duty both day and night. 34 These were heads of fathers' houses of the Levites, according to their generations, chief men. These lived in Jerusalem.
35 Jeiel[t] the father of Gibeon settled in Gibeon; the name of his wife was Maacah. 36 His firstborn son was Abdon, then Zur, Kish, Baal, Ner, Nadab, 37 Gedor, Ahio, Zechariah, and Mikloth. 38 Mikloth became the father of Shimeam. They also lived with their brothers in Jerusalem, over against their brothers. 39 Ner was the father of Kish. Kish was the father of Saul, and Saul had sons named Jonathan, Malchi-shua, Abinadab, and Esh-baal. 40 The son of Jonathan was Merib-baal; and Merib-baal[u] became the father of Micah. 41 The sons of Micah: Pithon, Melech, Tahrea, and Ahaz.[v] 42 Ahaz fathered Jarah, and Jarah fathered Alemeth, Azmaveth, and Zimri, and Zimri fathered Moza.[w] 43 Moza became the father of Binea; Rephaiah was his son, Eleasah his son, Azel his son. 44 Azel had six sons named Azrikam, Bocheru, Ishmael, Sheariah, Obadiah, and Hanan. These were Azel's sons.[x]

Notes

- a (9:1) Or "written in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah, and they were carried into exile." The Septuagint reads "the book of the kings of Israel and Judah." Babylon, Hebrew Babel (compare Genesis 11:9).

- b (9:2) Hebrew Nethinim, "those given." Verses 2–17 have a close parallel in Nehemiah 11:3–19.
- c (9:3) Ephraim, see 6:67; Manasseh, see 3:13; Jerusalem, perhaps "foundation of Shalem (peace)."
- d (9:4) Uthai, perhaps "Yahweh has helped"; Ammihud, see 7:26; Omri, see 7:8; Imri, "eloquent"; Bani, see 6:46; Perez, see 2:4.
- e (9:5) Shilonites, probably of Shelah (2:3; Numbers 26:20), rather than of the town of Shiloh. Asaiah, see 4:36.
- f (9:6) Jeuel, perhaps "God sweeps away" (a form of Jeiel). Zerah, see 2:4.
- g (9:7) Sallu, perhaps "weighed"; Meshullam, see 3:19; Hodaviah, see 3:24; Hassenuah, "the hated one."
- h (9:8) Ibneiah, "Yahweh builds"; Jeroham, see 6:27; Elah, see 1:52; Uzzi, see 6:5; Michri, perhaps "purchase price"; Shephatiah, see 3:3; Reuel, see 1:35; Ibnijah, "Yahweh builds."
- i (9:10) Jedaiah, see 4:37; Jehoiarib, "Yahweh contends"; Jachin, "he establishes." Compare 24:7, 17.
- j (9:11) Nehemiah 11:11 reads Seraiah. Hilkiah, Zadok, Meraioth, Ahitub, see 6:4–13.
- k (9:12) Adaiah, see 6:41; Pashhur, uncertain, perhaps Egyptian; Malchijah, see 6:40; Maasai, "work of Yahweh"; Adiel, see 4:36; Jahzerah, uncertain; Meshillemith, "recompense"; Immer, "lamb."
- l (9:14) Shemaiah, see 3:22; Hasshub, "considerate"; Azrikam, see 3:23; Hashabiah, see 6:45.
- m (9:15) Bakbakkar, uncertain; Heresh, "craftsman"; Galal, "rolling"; Mattaniah, "gift of Yahweh"; Mica, see Micah, 5:5; Zichri, see 8:19; Asaph, see 6:39.
- n (9:16) Jeduthun, perhaps "praising" (see 16:41); Berechiah, see 3:20; Asa, see 3:10; Elkanah, see 6:23; Netophathites, see 2:54.
- o (9:17) Shallum, see 2:40; Akkub, see 3:24; Talmon, "oppressor" or "brightness"; Ahiman, "my brother is a gift."
- p (9:19) Kore, "partridge" or "caller"; Ebiasaph, see 6:23; Korah, see 1:35.
- q (9:21) Zechariah, see 5:7; Meshelemiah, "Yahweh repays."
- r (9:31) Mattithiah, "gift of Yahweh." The flat cakes were baked on a griddle (Leviticus 2:5).
- s (9:32) Hebrew "bread of the rows," the bread laid out before Yahweh (Leviticus 24:5–9). Sabbath, "rest."
- t (9:35) So the Hebrew margin (Qere); the written text reads "Jeuel." Verses 35–44 repeat 8:29–38.
- u (9:40) The second time the Hebrew reads "Meri-baal."
- v (9:41) "And Ahaz" is supplied from 8:35; it is not in the Hebrew or the Septuagint (B text) here. Tahrea, see Tarea, 8:35.
- w (9:42) Jarah, "honeycomb" (8:36 Jehoaddah); for the others see 8:36.
- x (9:44) Compare 8:38. Shimeam (verse 38), see Shimeah, 8:32; Rephaiah, see 3:21.

Chapter 10

1 Now the Philistines fought against Israel, and the men of Israel fled
before the Philistines and fell slain on Mount Gilboa.[a] 2 The Philistines
closed in on Saul and his sons, and they killed Saul's sons Jonathan,
Abinadab, and Malchi-shua. 3 The fighting went sore against Saul; the
archers overtook him, and he was wounded by them. 4 Then Saul said
to his armor-bearer, "Draw your sword and thrust me through with
it, lest these uncircumcised men come and make sport of me." But
his armor-bearer would not, for he was greatly afraid. So Saul took
the sword and fell on it. 5 When his armor-bearer saw that Saul was
dead, he likewise fell on the sword and died. 6 So Saul died, and his
three sons, and all his house died together.[b] 7 When all the men of
Israel who were in the valley saw that they had fled, and that Saul
and his sons were dead, they abandoned their cities and fled; and the
Philistines came and lived in them.

8 The next day, when the Philistines came to strip the slain, they found
Saul and his sons fallen on Mount Gilboa. 9 They stripped him and
took his head and his armor, and sent into the land of the Philistines
all around, to carry the tidings to their idols and to the people. 10
They put his armor in the house of their gods, and fastened his skull
in the house of Dagon.[c] 11 When all Jabesh-gilead heard all that the
Philistines had done to Saul,[d] 12 all the valiant men arose and took
away the body of Saul and the bodies of his sons, and brought them to
Jabesh. They buried their bones under the oak[e] in Jabesh, and fasted
seven days.

13 So Saul died for his unfaithfulness that he committed against
Yahweh, because he did not keep the word of Yahweh, and also
because he consulted a medium, seeking guidance,[f] 14 and did not seek
guidance from Yahweh. Therefore he put him to death and turned the
kingdom over to David the son of Jesse.[g]

Notes

- a (10:1) Verses 1–12 parallel 1 Samuel 31:1–13. Philistines, a people of the coast, perhaps "wanderers"; Gilboa, perhaps "bubbling spring."

- b (10:6) First Samuel 31:6 reads "his armor-bearer and all his men died together that day." Chronicles makes the end of Saul's dynasty explicit, though a son, Esh-baal (Ish-bosheth), survived (8:33; 2 Samuel 2:8).
- c (10:10) According to 1 Samuel 31:10, the Philistines placed his armor in the temple of the Ashtaroth and nailed his body to the wall of Beth-shan. Dagon was a Philistine god of grain or of fish.
- d (10:11) Jabesh-gilead, "dry place of Gilead."
- e (10:12) First Samuel 31:13 reads "under the tamarisk tree." Chronicles also omits the burning of the bodies (1 Samuel 31:12).
- f (10:13) See 1 Samuel 13:13–14; 15:22–23; 28:6–19. Verses 13–14 have no parallel in Samuel. Saul is said not to have sought Yahweh, though 1 Samuel 28:6 says Yahweh did not answer him.
- g (10:14) David, see 2:15; Jesse, see 2:12.

Chapter 11

1 Then all Israel gathered to David at Hebron, saying, "Look, we are
your bone and your flesh.[a] 2 In times past, even when Saul was king,
it was you who led Israel out and brought them in. And Yahweh your
God said to you, 'You shall shepherd my people Israel, and you shall
be prince over my people Israel.'" 3 So all the elders of Israel came to
the king at Hebron, and David made a covenant with them at Hebron
before Yahweh. And they anointed David king over Israel, according
to the word of Yahweh by Samuel.[b]
4 David and all Israel went to Jerusalem, that is, Jebus, where the
Jebusites, the inhabitants of the land, were.[c] 5 The inhabitants of
Jebus said to David, "You will not come in here." Nevertheless David
took the stronghold of Zion, that is, the city of David.[d] 6 David had
said, "Whoever is first to attack the Jebusites will be made chief and
commander." Joab son of Zeruiah went up first, and so he became the
chief.[e] 7 David dwelt in the stronghold; for this reason they called it
the city of David. 8 He built up the city around it, from the Millo to the
surrounding wall, and Joab restored the rest of the city.[f] 9 And David
became greater and greater, for Yahweh of Armies was with him.[g]
10 These were the leaders among David's warriors, who stood firmly
with him in his kingdom, along with all Israel, to make him king, as
Yahweh had promised concerning Israel.[h] 11 This is the list of David's
mighty men: Jashobeam, a Hachmonite, chief of the thirty;[i] he lifted

up his spear against three hundred whom he killed at one time.[j] 12 After him was Eleazar the son of Dodo, the Ahohite; he was one of the three mighty men.[k] 13 He was with David at Pas-dammim, and there the Philistines were gathered together to battle, where was a plot of ground full of barley; and the people fled from before the Philistines.[l] 14 But they took their stand in the middle of the plot and defended it, and struck down the Philistines; and Yahweh saved them by a great victory.

15 Three of the thirty chiefs went down to the rock to David, to the cave of Adullam, while the army of the Philistines was encamped in the Valley of Rephaim.[m] 16 David was then in the stronghold, and the garrison of the Philistines was then at Bethlehem. 17 David was thirsty and said, "If only someone would bring me a drink of water from the well by the gate of Bethlehem!" 18 So the three broke through the Philistine camp and drew water from Bethlehem's well, the one by the gate. They carried it back to David, but he would not drink it. He poured it out before Yahweh as an offering 19 and said, "May my God keep me from doing this! Can I drink the blood of these men who risked their lives? They risked their lives to bring it." So he would not drink it. Such were the deeds of the three warriors.

20 Abishai, Joab's brother, was the leader of the three.[n] He swung his spear against three hundred men and killed them, and he earned a reputation among the three. 21 Of the three he was more honored than the two,[o] and he was made their captain; however, he did not attain to the first three. 22 Benaiah son of Jehoiada from Kabzeel was a brave man who did great deeds. He killed two sons of Ariel[p] of Moab, and he went down into a pit and killed a lion on a snowy day.[q] 23 He also struck down an Egyptian of great height, seven and a half feet tall.[r] The Egyptian held a spear as thick as a weaver's beam, but Benaiah approached him with a club, tore the spear out of the Egyptian's grip, and killed him with it. 24 Such were the deeds of Benaiah son of Jehoiada, who earned a name along with the three warriors. 25 He was honored among the thirty, but he did not attain to the three. And David set him over his bodyguard.

26 The mighty men of the armies were Asahel the brother of Joab,
Elhanan the son of Dodo of Bethlehem,[s] 27 Shammoth the Harorite,
Helez the Pelonite,[t] 28 Ira the son of Ikkesh the Tekoite, Abiezer the
Anathothite,[u] 29 Sibbecai the Hushathite, Ilai the Ahohite,[v] 30 Maharai
from Netophah, and Heled son of Baanah from Netophah,[w] 31 Ithai
son of Ribai from Gibeah of the Benjaminites, and Benaiah from
Pirathon,[x] 32 Hurai of the brooks of Gaash, Abiel the Arbathite,[y] 33
Azmaveth the Baharumite, Eliahba the Shaalbonite,[z] 34 the sons of
Hashem the Gizonite, Jonathan the son of Shagee the Hararite,[aa] 35
Ahiam son of Sachar the Hararite, Eliphal son of Ur,[ab] 36 Hepher the
Mecherathite, Ahijah the Pelonite,[ac] 37 Hezro from Carmel, and Naarai
son of Ezbai,[ad] 38 Joel, Nathan's brother, and Mibhar son of Hagri,[ae]
39 Zelek from Ammon, and Naharai from Beeroth, who carried the
armor of Joab son of Zeruiah,[af] 40 Ira from the Ithrites, and Gareb from
the Ithrites,[ag] 41 Uriah from the Hittites, and Zabad son of Ahlai,[ah] 42
Adina son of Shiza, a Reubenite who led the Reubenites, along with
thirty men who were with him,[ai] 43 Hanan the son of Maacah, and
Joshaphat the Mithnite,[aj] 44 Uzzia the Ashterathite, Shama and Jeiel the
sons of Hotham the Aroerite,[ak] 45 Jediael the son of Shimri, and Joha his
brother, the Tizite,[al] 46 Eliel the Mahavite, and Jeribai and Joshaviah the
sons of Elnaam, and Ithmah the Moabite,[am] 47 Eliel, Obed, and Jaasiel
the Mezobaite.[an]

Notes

- a (11:1) Verses 1–9 parallel 2 Samuel 5:1–10. Chronicles omits David's seven years as king over Judah alone (2 Samuel 2–4).
- b (11:3) See 1 Samuel 16:1–13.
- c (11:4) Jebus, perhaps "trodden down"; compare 1:14. Second Samuel 5:6 says "the king and his men."
- d (11:5) Zion, perhaps "fortress" or "dry place." Chronicles omits the saying about the blind and the lame (2 Samuel 5:6, 8).
- e (11:6) Second Samuel 5:8 does not name Joab here. Joab, see 2:16.
- f (11:8) Millo means "filling," probably a terrace or earthwork.
- g (11:9) Hebrew Yahweh Tseba'oth, often rendered "Yahweh of hosts": Yahweh as commander of the armies of heaven and of Israel. This is its first appearance in this book.
- h (11:10) Verses 10–41 parallel 2 Samuel 23:8–39; verses 41b–47 are found only in Chronicles.

- i (11:11) So the written Hebrew text (Ketiv) and the Septuagint; the Hebrew margin (Qere) reads "the officers." Second Samuel 23:8 calls him Josheb-basshebeth (perhaps a scribal change of Ish-baal) and "chief of the three." Jashobeam, "the people will return"; Hachmonite, "wise."
- j (11:11) Second Samuel 23:8 reads "eight hundred." The Septuagint (B text) here also reads "three hundred."
- k (11:12) Eleazar, see 6:3; Dodo, "his beloved"; Ahohite, of Ahoah (8:4).
- l (11:13) Pas-dammim (1 Samuel 17:1 Ephes-dammim), "boundary of blood." Here Chronicles passes from Eleazar's deed to that of Shammah (2 Samuel 23:11–12), apparently because a line dropped out; in Samuel the field was full of lentils.
- m (11:15) Or "Three of the thirty, the chiefs"; 2 Samuel 23:13. Adullam, perhaps "refuge"; Rephaim, "ghosts" or "giants."
- n (11:20) So the Hebrew; the Syriac reads "the thirty" (also in verse 21 and 2 Samuel 23:18). Abishai, see 2:16.
- o (11:21) Or "Of the three he was doubly honored."
- p (11:22) Ariel, "lion of God"; Hebrew "two Ariel of Moab," perhaps meaning "two champions."
- q (11:22) Benaiah, see 4:36; Jehoiada, "Yahweh knows"; Kabzeel, "God gathers."
- r (11:23) Hebrew "five cubits" (about 2.3 meters). Second Samuel 23:21 does not give his height.
- s (11:26) Elhanan, "God is gracious"; Asahel, see 2:16.
- t (11:27) Second Samuel 23:25 reads "Shammah the Harodite" and adds "Elika the Harodite." Shammoth, "desolations"; Harorite, perhaps from Harod ("trembling"); Helez, see 2:39; Pelonite, uncertain (2 Samuel 23:26 Paltite).
- u (11:28) Ira, "watchful"; Ikkesh, "perverse"; Tekoite, of Tekoa (2:24); Abiezer, see 7:18; Anathothite, of Anathoth (6:60).
- v (11:29) Sibbecai (2 Samuel 23:27 Mebunnai), perhaps "Yahweh has interwoven"; Hushathite, of Hushah (4:4); Ilai (2 Samuel 23:28 Zalmon), uncertain.
- w (11:30) Maharai, "hasty"; Heled (2 Samuel 23:29 Heleb), "duration"; Baanah, perhaps "son of affliction."
- x (11:31) Ithai (2 Samuel 23:29 Ittai), uncertain; Ribai, "Yahweh contends"; Gibeah, "hill"; Pirathonite, of Pirathon (Judges 12:15).
- y (11:32) Hurai (2 Samuel 23:30 Hiddai), uncertain; Gaash, "quaking"; Abiel, "God is father"; Arbathite, of Beth-arabah (2 Samuel 23:31 Abi-albon).
- z (11:33) Azmaveth, see 8:36; Baharumite, of Bahurim; Eliahba, "God hides"; Shaalbonite, of Shaalbim ("foxes").
- aa (11:34) Second Samuel 23:32 reads "the sons of Jashen." Hashem, "name"; Gizonite, uncertain; Shagee (2 Samuel 23:33 Shammah), uncertain; Hararite, perhaps "mountaineer."
- ab (11:35) Ahiam, "mother's brother"; Sachar (2 Samuel 23:33 Sharar), "reward"; Eliphal (2 Samuel 23:34 Eliphelet), "God judges"; Ur, "flame."

- ac (11:36) Hepher, see 4:6; Mecherathite, uncertain; Ahijah, see 2:25. Second Samuel 23:34 reads here "Eliphelet the son of Ahasbai the Maacathite, Eliam the son of Ahithophel the Gilonite."
- ad (11:37) Hezro, "enclosure"; Naarai (2 Samuel 23:35 Paarai the Arbite), "youthful"; Ezbai, uncertain.
- ae (11:38) Joel (2 Samuel 23:36 Igal), see 4:35; Nathan, see 2:36; Mibhar, "choice"; Hagri, "wanderer" (2 Samuel 23:36 "Bani the Gadite").
- af (11:39) Zelek, "cleft"; Ammonite, of Ammon ("people"); Naharai, "snorer"; Berothite, of Beeroth ("wells").
- ag (11:40) Ira, see verse 28; Ithrite, of Jether's clan (2:53); Gareb, "scabby."
- ah (11:41) Second Samuel 23:39 ends the list with Uriah, adding "thirty-seven in all." Uriah, "Yahweh is my light"; Hittite, see 1:13; Zabad, see 2:36; Ahlai, see 2:31.
- ai (11:42) Verses 42–47 are not in 2 Samuel. Adina, "delicate"; Shiza, uncertain. "And thirty with him" may mean "and over him were thirty."
- aj (11:43) Hanan, see 8:23; Maacah, see 2:48; Joshaphat, "Yahweh has judged"; Mithnite, uncertain.
- ak (11:44) Uzzia, "Yahweh is my strength"; Ashterathite, of Ashtaroth (6:71); Shama, "he heard"; Jeiel, see 5:7 (Hebrew written text Jeuel); Hotham, see 7:32; Aroerite, of Aroer (5:8).
- al (11:45) Jediael, see 7:6; Shimri, see 4:37; Joha, see 8:16; Tizite, uncertain.
- am (11:46) Eliel, see 5:24; Mahavite, uncertain; Jeribai, "Yahweh contends"; Joshaviah, "Yahweh lets dwell"; Elnaam, "God is pleasantness"; Ithmah, "bereavement"; Moabite, of Moab (8:8).
- an (11:47) Obed, see 2:12; Jaasiel, "God makes"; Mezobaite, perhaps of Zobah.

Chapter 12

1 Now these are they who came to David to Ziklag, while he yet kept
himself close because of Saul the son of Kish.[a] They were among
the mighty men, his helpers in war. 2 They were armed with bows
and could use both the right hand and the left in slinging stones
and shooting arrows from the bow; they were of Saul's kinsmen, of
Benjamin.[b] 3 The chief was Ahiezer, then Joash, the sons of Shemaah
the Gibeathite; and Jeziel and Pelet the sons of Azmaveth; and
Beracah, and Jehu the Anathothite;[c] 4 and Ishmaiah the Gibeonite,
a mighty man among the thirty and over the thirty; and Jeremiah,
Jahaziel, Johanan, and Jozabad the Gederathite;[d] 5 Eluzai, Jerimoth,
Bealiah, Shemariah, and Shephatiah the Haruphite;[e] 6 Elkanah, Is-
shiah, Azarel, Joezer, and Jashobeam, the Korahites;[f] 7 and Joelah and
Zebadiah, the sons of Jeroham of Gedor.[g]

8 From the Gadites some separated themselves to David in the stronghold in the wilderness, mighty men of valor, men of war fit for battle,
who could handle shield and spear, whose faces were like the faces of
lions, and who were as swift as gazelles on the mountains:[h] 9 Ezer the
chief, Obadiah second, Eliab third,[i] 10 Mishmannah fourth, Jeremiah
fifth,[j] 11 Attai sixth, Eliel seventh,[k] 12 Johanan eighth, Elzabad ninth,[l]
13 Jeremiah tenth, Machbannai eleventh.[m] 14 These of the sons of Gad
were captains of the army; the least was equal to a hundred, and the
greatest to a thousand.[n] 15 These are they who went over the Jordan
in the first month (in March–April), when it had overflowed all its
banks;[o] and they chased away all of the valleys, both toward the east
and toward the west.
16 Some of the sons of Benjamin and Judah came to the stronghold to
David. 17 David went out to meet them and said, "If you have come to
me peacefully, to help me, I am ready to unite with you. But if you
have come to hand me over to my enemies though I have done no
wrong, may the God of our ancestors see this and pass judgment." 18
Then the Spirit took hold of Amasai, the leader of the Thirty,[p] who
said, "We are yours, David! We are with you, son of Jesse! Peace, peace
to you, and peace to your helpers, because your God helps you." So
David received them and put them in charge of his raiding bands.
19 Some men of Manasseh also went over to David when he marched
with the Philistines to fight against Saul. But David did not assist the
Philistines, because after consulting together their rulers sent him
away, saying, "He will change sides to his master Saul, and it will
cost us our heads."[q] 20 As he went to Ziklag, there deserted to him
from Manasseh Adnah, and Jozabad, and Jediael, and Michael, and
Jozabad, and Elihu, and Zillethai, captains of thousands who belonged
to Manasseh.[r] 21 They supported David against the raiding party,[s] for
all of them were brave warriors and became commanders in his army.
22 Day after day men came to David to help him, until his camp was
large, like a camp of God.[t]
23 These are the numbers of the armed troops who reached David
at Hebron to transfer Saul's kingdom to him, as Yahweh had said:[u]
24 The sons of Judah who bore shield and spear were six thousand

eight hundred, armed for war. 25 Of the sons of Simeon, mighty men
of valor for war, seven thousand one hundred. 26 Of the sons of Levi,
four thousand six hundred. 27 Jehoiada was the leader of the house
of Aaron, and with him were three thousand seven hundred;[v] 28 and
Zadok, a young man, a mighty man of valor, and twenty-two captains
of his father's house.[w] 29 Of the sons of Benjamin, the kinsmen of Saul,
three thousand, for until then the greater part of them had kept their
allegiance to the house of Saul. 30 Of the sons of Ephraim, twenty
thousand eight hundred, mighty men of valor, famous men in their
fathers' houses. 31 From the half-tribe of Manasseh, 18,000 men, who
were named individually to go and make David king. 32 From the
descendants of Issachar, 200 leaders, who understood the times and
knew what Israel should do, together with all their relatives who were
under their command.[x] 33 Of Zebulun, such as were able to go out in
the host, who could set the battle in array with all manner of instru-
ments of war, fifty thousand, to help David[y] with an undivided heart.
34 Of Naphtali, a thousand captains, and with them, with shield and
spear, thirty-seven thousand. 35 Of the Danites, twenty-eight thousand
six hundred ready for battle. 36 Of Asher, forty thousand who could
go out in the army, ready for battle. 37 From beyond the Jordan, of the
Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, one hundred
and twenty thousand with all kinds of weapons of war.[z]
38 All these were men of war who could order the battle line; they came
with a perfect heart to Hebron to make David king over all Israel;
and all the rest of Israel too were of one heart to make David king.
39 They were there with David three days, eating and drinking, for
their kinsmen had made provision for them. 40 Moreover those who
were near to them, as far as Issachar, Zebulun, and Naphtali, brought
food on donkeys, on camels, on mules, and on oxen: provisions of
flour, cakes of figs, clusters of raisins, wine, oil, oxen, and sheep in
abundance; for there was joy in Israel.

Notes

- a (12:1) Ziklag, perhaps "winding"; Kish, see 8:30. See 1 Samuel 27:6. This chapter has no parallel in Samuel.

- b (12:2) Benjamin, “son of the right hand,” makes the skill with the left hand notable (compare Judges 20:16).
- c (12:3) So the Hebrew margin (Qere); the written text (Ketiv) reads Jezuel. Ahiezer, “my brother is help”; Joash, “Yahweh has given”; Shemaah, “report”; Gibeathite, of Gibeah (“hill”); Jeziel, perhaps “God sprinkles”; Pelet, see 2:47; Beracah, “blessing”; Jehu, “Yahweh is he”; Anathothite, see 11:28.
- d (12:4) English verse 4 is Hebrew verses 4–5, so the Hebrew numbering of this chapter is one higher from here to the end (English 12:40 = Hebrew 12:41). Ishmaiah, “Yahweh hears”; Gibeonite, of Gibeon (“hill”); Jeremiah, “Yahweh exalts”; Jahaziel, “God sees”; Johanan, see 3:15; Jozabad, “Yahweh has given”; Gederathite, of Gederah (“sheepfold,” 4:23).
- e (12:5) So the Hebrew margin (Qere); the written text (Ketiv) reads Hariphite. Eluzai, “God is my strength”; Jerimoth, see 7:7; Bealiah, “Yahweh is lord”; Shemariah, “Yahweh guards”; Shephatiah, see 3:3.
- f (12:6) Elkanah, see 6:23; Isshiah, “Yahweh lends”; Azarel, “God helps”; Joezer, “Yahweh is help”; Jashobeam, see 11:11; Korahites, descendants of Korah (2:43), possibly a Benjaminite family of that name rather than the Levites.
- g (12:7) Joelah, perhaps “may he avail”; Zebadiah, “Yahweh has given”; Jeroham, see 6:27; Gedor, “wall” (4:4).
- h (12:8) Gadites, of Gad (“fortune”).
- i (12:9) Ezer, “help”; Obadiah, “servant of Yahweh”; Eliab, see 2:13.
- j (12:10) Mishmannah, “fatness”; Jeremiah, see verse 4.
- k (12:11) Attai, see 2:35; Eliel, see 5:24.
- l (12:12) Johanan, see 3:15; Elzabad, “God has given.”
- m (12:13) Machbannai, perhaps “clad with a mantle.”
- n (12:14) Or “one was over a hundred, and the greatest over a thousand.”
- o (12:15) Hebrew “the first month” (Nisan, from the spring new year), the season of the barley harvest, when the Jordan floods (Joshua 3:15). “Banks”: so the Hebrew margin (Qere).
- p (12:18) So the written Hebrew text (Ketiv); the Hebrew margin (Qere) reads “the officers.” Amasai, “burden-bearer” (6:25); some identify him with Amasa (2 Samuel 17:25).
- q (12:19) See 1 Samuel 29:1–11. Manasseh, “causing to forget.”
- r (12:20) Adnah, “pleasure”; Jozabad, see verse 4; Jediael, see 7:6; Michael, see 5:13; Elihu, “he is my God”; Zillethai, “shade.”
- s (12:21) Probably the Amalekite raiders of 1 Samuel 30.
- t (12:22) Or “a very great army.”
- u (12:23) Verses 23–37 are a tribal muster list found only in Chronicles; some take the Hebrew ’eleph here as “unit” rather than “thousand.”
- v (12:27) Jehoiada, see 11:22; Aaron, see 6:3.
- w (12:28) Zadok, see 6:8.
- x (12:32) Issachar, perhaps “there is reward.”

- y (12:33) So the Septuagint; Hebrew lacks “David.” Zebulun, “dwelling.”
- z (12:37) Reubenites, of Reuben (“see, a son”).

Chapter 13

1 David consulted with the captains of thousands and of hundreds,
with every leader. 2 David told the whole assembly of Israel, “If you
approve, and if this is from Yahweh our God, let us send messages
in every direction to the rest of our relatives throughout the land of
Israel, and to the priests and Levites in the towns with pasturelands,
inviting them to join us. 3 Let us bring the ark of our God back to us,
since we did not consult it during the reign of Saul.”[a] 4 All the assembly
said that they would do so, for the thing was right in the eyes of all
the people.
5 So David assembled all Israel, from the Shihor of Egypt even to the
entrance of Hamath, to bring the ark of God from Kiriath-jearim.[b]
6 And David and all Israel went up to Baalah, that is, to Kiriath-
jearim, which belongs to Judah, to bring up from there the ark of God,
Yahweh, who sits enthroned above the cherubim, where his name is
called.[c] 7 They carried the ark of God on a new cart from the house
of Abinadab, and Uzza and Ahio drove the cart.[d] 8 David and all Israel
played before God with all their might, even with songs, and with
lyres, and with harps, and with tambourines, and with cymbals, and
with trumpets.
9 When they reached the threshing floor of Chidon, Uzza reached out
to steady the ark, because the oxen had stumbled.[e] 10 The anger of
Yahweh burned against Uzza, and he struck him because he put his
hand to the ark; and there he died before God. 11 David was angry
because Yahweh had broken out against Uzza; and that place is called
Perez-uzza to this day.[f] 12 David was afraid of God that day, saying,
“How can I bring the ark of God home to me?” 13 So David did not
take the ark home to himself in the city of David, but turned it aside
into the house of Obed-edom the Gittite.[g] 14 The ark of God stayed
three months in Obed-edom’s house, with his family. Yahweh blessed
Obed-edom’s household and everything he owned.

Notes

- a (13:3) Verses 5–14 parallel 2 Samuel 6:1–11. Verses 1–4 are found only in Chronicles.
- b (13:5) Shihor, "black" or "turbid," probably a branch of the Nile or the Wadi of Egypt; Hamath, "fortress." Lebo-hamath may be a place name. Kiriath-jearim, "city of forests."
- c (13:6) Baalah, "mistress." Second Samuel 6:2 reads "Baale-judah." Cherubim, winged guardian figures.
- d (13:7) Abinadab, see 2:13 (a different man); Uzza, "strength"; Ahio, "his brother" (the Septuagint takes it as "his brothers").
- e (13:9) Second Samuel 6:6 reads "Nacon." Chidon may mean "javelin."
- f (13:11) Perez-uzza means "outburst against Uzza."
- g (13:13) Obed-edom, "servant of Edom"; Gittite, of Gath ("winepress").

Chapter 14

1 Hiram king of Tyre sent messengers to David, with cedar trees,
masons, and carpenters, to build him a house.[a] 2 And David knew that
Yahweh had established him as king over Israel, for his kingdom was
highly exalted for the sake of his people Israel.
3 David took more wives at Jerusalem, and David became the father
of more sons and daughters. 4 These are the names of the children
born to him in Jerusalem: Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, and Solomon;[b]
5 and Ibhar, Elishua, and Elpelet;[c] 6 and Nogah, Nepheg, and Japhia; 7
and Elishama, Beeliada, and Eliphelet.[d]
8 When the Philistines heard that David had been anointed king over
all Israel, all the Philistines went up to seek David. David heard of it
and went out against them. 9 Now the Philistines had come and made
a raid in the Valley of Rephaim. 10 David asked God, "Should I go to
war against the Philistines? Will you deliver them to me?" Yahweh
answered him, "Go to war, and I will deliver them to you." 11 So the
Philistines went up to Baal-perazim, and David defeated them there.
He said, "By my hand God has burst through my enemies like a flood."
That is why the place was named Baal-perazim.[e] 12 The Philistines
abandoned their gods there, and David ordered that they be burned
in a fire.[f]
13 Yet again the Philistines made a raid in the valley. 14 And when
David inquired again of God, God said to him, "You shall not go up
after them. Turn away from them and come against them opposite

the balsam trees.[g] 15 When you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the balsam trees, then go out to battle, for God has gone out before you to strike the army of the Philistines." 16 David did as God commanded him, and they struck down the army of the Philistines from Gibeon to Gezer.[h] 17 And the fame of David went out into all lands, and Yahweh brought the fear of him upon all nations.

Notes

- a (14:1) Verses 1–16 parallel 2 Samuel 5:11–25. Hiram, perhaps "my brother is exalted"; Tyre, "rock." The Hebrew margin (Qere) reads Hiram; the written text (Ketiv) reads Huram.
- b (14:4) Compare the list at 3:5–8. Shammua (3:5 Shimea), "heard"; Shobab, see 2:18; Nathan, see 2:36; Solomon, see 3:5.
- c (14:5) Elpelet corresponds to Eliphelet in 3:6. Ibhar, see 3:6; Elishua, "God is salvation."
- d (14:7) Beeliada, "the Lord knows" (3:8 Eliada, "God knows," perhaps a later change avoiding the name Baal). Second Samuel 5:14–16 omits Nogah and Elpelet.
- e (14:11) Baal-perazim means "lord of breakings through."
- f (14:12) Second Samuel 5:21 says that David and his men carried the idols away. Chronicles says they were burned, as Deuteronomy 7:5, 25 commands.
- g (14:14) Or "baca trees"; the exact kind of tree is uncertain.
- h (14:16) Second Samuel 5:25 reads "from Geba." Gezer, "portion."

Chapter 15

1 David made houses for himself in the city of David, and he prepared a place for the ark of God and pitched a tent for it. 2 Then David said, "Only the Levites may carry the ark of God, because Yahweh chose them to carry Yahweh's ark and to serve him always."[a] 3 And David assembled all Israel at Jerusalem to bring up the ark of Yahweh to its place, which he had prepared for it. 4 David gathered together the sons of Aaron and the Levites: 5 of the sons of Kohath, Uriel the chief, and his brothers, a hundred and twenty;[b] 6 of the sons of Merari, Asaiah the chief, and his brothers, two hundred and twenty;[c] 7 of the sons of Gershom, Joel the chief, and his brothers, a hundred and thirty;[d] 8 of the sons of Elizaphan, Shemaiah the chief, and his brothers, two hundred;[e] 9 of the sons of Hebron, Eliel the chief, and his brothers, eighty;[f] 10 of the sons of Uzziel, Amminadab the chief, and his brothers, a hundred and twelve.[g]

11 David called for Zadok and Abiathar the priests, and for the Levites,
for Uriel, Asaiah, Joel, Shemaiah, Eliel, and Amminadab,[h] 12 and said to
them, "You are the heads of the fathers' houses of the Levites. Sanctify
yourselves, both you and your brothers, that you may bring up the
ark of Yahweh, the God of Israel, to the place that I have prepared for
it. 13 For because you did not bear it at the first, Yahweh our God made
a breach upon us, for we did not seek him after the ordinance." 14 So
the priests and the Levites sanctified themselves to bring up the ark
of Yahweh, the God of Israel. 15 The sons of the Levites bore the ark of
God upon their shoulders with its poles, just as Moses commanded
by the word of Yahweh.[i]
16 David also told the chiefs of the Levites to appoint their brothers
as the singers, with instruments of music, harps and lyres and cym-
bals, sounding aloud, to lift up the voice with joy. 17 So the Levites
appointed Heman the son of Joel; and of his brothers, Asaph the son
of Berechiah; and of the sons of Merari their brothers, Ethan the son
of Kushaiah;[j] 18 and with them their second-rank relatives: Zechariah,
Ben,[k] Jaaziel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Benaiah, Maaseiah,
Mattithiah, Eliphelehu, and Mikneiah, along with the gatekeepers
Obed-edom and Jeiel.[l] 19 The singers, Heman, Asaph, and Ethan, were
to sound aloud with cymbals of bronze; 20 Zechariah, Aziel, Shemi-
ramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Maaseiah, and Benaiah, with harps set to
Alamoth;[m] 21 and Mattithiah, Eliphelehu, Mikneiah, Obed-edom, Jeiel,
and Azaziah, with lyres set to the Sheminith, to lead.[n] 22 Chenaniah,
chief of the Levites in carrying, was in charge of the carrying; he gave
instruction about it, because he was skillful.[o] 23 Berechiah and Elkanah
were doorkeepers for the ark.[p] 24 Shebaniah, Joshaphat, Nethanel,
Amasai, Zechariah, Benaiah, and Eliezer, the priests, were to blow
the trumpets before the ark of God. Obed-edom and Jehiah were
doorkeepers for the ark.[q]
25 So David and the elders of Israel and the captains of thousands went
to bring up the ark of the covenant of Yahweh from the house of
Obed-edom with joy.[r] 26 Because God was helping the Levites who
carried Yahweh's covenant ark, seven bulls and seven rams were
offered.[s] 27 David wore a robe of fine linen, as did all the Levites

carrying the ark, the singers, and Chenaniah, who directed the music of the singers;[t] David also wore a linen ephod. 28 So all Israel brought up the ark of the covenant of Yahweh with shouting, with the sound of the horn, with trumpets, and with cymbals, sounding aloud with harps and lyres. 29 As Yahweh's covenant ark entered the city of David, Michal daughter of Saul watched from a window. She saw King David leaping and celebrating, and she despised him in her heart.[u]

Notes

- a (15:2) See Numbers 4:15; Deuteronomy 10:8. Levites, of Levi ("joined").
- b (15:5) Kohath, see 6:1; Uriel, see 6:24.
- c (15:6) Merari, see 6:1; Asaiah, see 4:36.
- d (15:7) Gershom (Gershon), see 6:1; Joel, see 4:35.
- e (15:8) Elizaphan, "God has hidden," a Kohathite (Numbers 3:30); Shemaiah, see 3:22.
- f (15:9) Hebron, see 6:2; Eliel, see 5:24.
- g (15:10) Uzziel, see 6:2; Amminadab, see 6:22.
- h (15:11) Zadok, see 6:8; Abiathar, "the father is abundant."
- i (15:15) See Exodus 25:14; Numbers 7:9. Moses, see 6:3.
- j (15:17) Heman, see 6:33; Asaph, see 6:39; Berechiah, see 3:20; Ethan, see 6:42; Kushaiah (6:44 Kishi), perhaps "bow of Yahweh."
- k (15:18) Ben ("son") is probably a copying error; it is lacking in the Septuagint and in verse 20.
- l (15:18) Zechariah, see 5:7; Jaaziel (verse 20 Aziel), "God strengthens"; Shemiramoth, perhaps "name of heights"; Jehiel, "God lives"; Unni, perhaps "afflicted"; Eliab, see 2:13; Benaiah, see 4:36; Maaseiah, "work of Yahweh"; Mattithiah, "gift of Yahweh"; Eliphelehu, "God distinguishes him"; Mikneiah, "possession of Yahweh"; Obed-edom, see 13:13; Jeiel, see 5:7.
- m (15:20) Alamoth, "young women," probably a musical term for a higher register (compare Psalm 46 heading).
- n (15:21) Sheminith, "the eighth," probably a musical term for a lower register or an eight-stringed instrument (compare Psalms 6, 12 headings). Azaziah, "Yahweh is strong."
- o (15:22) Or "in charge of the music … he instructed in music"; the Hebrew massa' can mean "carrying" or "lifting up the voice." Chenaniah, "Yahweh establishes."
- p (15:23) Elkanah, see 6:23.
- q (15:24) Shebaniah, "Yahweh has brought back"; Joshaphat, see 11:43; Nethanel, see 2:14; Amasai, see 6:25; Eliezer, "God is help"; Jehiah, "Yahweh lives."
- r (15:25) Verses 25–29 parallel 2 Samuel 6:12–16.
- s (15:26) Second Samuel 6:13 says that when the bearers had gone six paces he sacrificed an ox and a fatling.

- t (15:27) Second Samuel 6:14 says only that David danced with all his might, wearing a linen ephod. "Of the singers" is perhaps a copying addition. An ephod was a linen garment worn by priests.
- u (15:29) Michal, "who is like God?"

Chapter 16

1 They brought in the ark of God and set it inside the tent that David had pitched for it, and they offered burnt offerings and peace offerings before God.[a] 2 When David had finished offering the burnt offerings and the peace offerings, he blessed the people in the name of Yahweh, 3 and he distributed to everyone of Israel, both man and woman, to each a loaf of bread, a portion of meat,[b] and a cake of raisins.

4 He appointed some of the Levites to minister before the ark of Yahweh, to commemorate, to thank, and to praise Yahweh, the God of Israel: 5 Asaph the chief, and second to him Zechariah, then Jeiel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Mattithiah, Eliab, Benaiah, Obed-edom, and Jeiel, with harps and with lyres; and Asaph was to sound the cymbals;[c] 6 and the priests Benaiah and Jahaziel were to sound the trumpets continually before the covenant ark of God.[d]

7 Then on that day David for the first time committed to Asaph and his brothers the giving of thanks to Yahweh: 8 Give thanks to Yahweh; call on his name. Make his deeds known among the peoples.[e] 9 Sing to him; sing praises to him. Tell of all his marvelous works. 10 Glory in his holy name. Let the heart of those who seek Yahweh rejoice. 11 Seek Yahweh and his strength. Seek his face continually. 12 Remember his wonderful works that he has done, his wonders, and the judgments of his mouth, 13 you offspring of Israel his servant, you children of Jacob, his chosen ones.[f] 14 He is Yahweh our God. His judgments are in all the earth. 15 Remember his covenant forever,[g] the word which he commanded to a thousand generations, 16 the covenant which he made with Abraham, his oath to Isaac. 17 He confirmed it to Jacob for a statute, to Israel for an everlasting covenant, 18 saying, "To you I will give the land of Canaan, the portion of your inheritance," 19 when you were but few in number,[h] very few, and sojourners in it. 20 They went about from nation to nation, from one kingdom to another people. 21

He allowed no man to do them wrong. Yes, he reproved kings for their
sakes: 22 "Do not touch my anointed ones! Do my prophets no harm!"
23 Sing to Yahweh, all the earth![i] Proclaim his salvation from day to
day. 24 Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works
among all the peoples. 25 For great is Yahweh, and greatly to be
praised. He is to be feared above all gods. 26 For all the gods of the peo-
ples are idols,[j] but Yahweh made the heavens. 27 Honor and majesty
are before him. Strength and joy are in his place.[k] 28 Ascribe to Yahweh,
you families of the peoples, ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength. 29
Ascribe to Yahweh the glory due to his name. Bring an offering, and
come before him. Worship Yahweh in holy array.[l] 30 Tremble before
him, all the earth. The world also is established, so that it cannot be
moved. 31 Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice! Let them
say among the nations, "Yahweh reigns!" 32 Let the sea roar, and its
fullness! Let the field rejoice, and all that is therein! 33 Then the trees
of the forest will sing for joy before Yahweh, for he comes to judge
the earth. 34 O give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good;[m] for his steadfast
love endures forever. 35 Say, "Save us, God of our salvation! Gather us
together and deliver us from the nations, that we may give thanks to
your holy name, and glory in your praise." 36 Blessed be Yahweh, the
God of Israel, from everlasting even to everlasting. And all the people
said, "Amen," and praised Yahweh.[n]
37 David left Asaph and his relatives there in front of Yahweh's
covenant ark, to serve before the ark continually according to each
day's needs, 38 and Obed-edom with his brothers, sixty-eight; and
Obed-edom the son of Jeduthun and Hosah to be gatekeepers.[o] 39
And he left Zadok the priest and his brothers the priests before the
tabernacle of Yahweh in the high place that was at Gibeon,[p] 40 to offer
burnt offerings to Yahweh on the altar of burnt offering continually
morning and evening, according to all that is written in the Law of
Yahweh, which he commanded Israel. 41 With them were Heman and
Jeduthun, and the rest who were chosen, who were mentioned by
name, to give thanks to Yahweh, because his steadfast love endures
forever.[q] 42 Heman and Jeduthun had trumpets and cymbals for those
who should sound aloud, and instruments for the songs of God. The

sons of Jeduthun were to be at the gate. 43 Then all the people went home, and David went back to bless his own household.[r]

Notes

- a (16:1) Verses 1–3 parallel 2 Samuel 6:17–19.
- b (16:3) The meaning of the Hebrew 'eshpar is uncertain; others suggest "a date cake."
- c (16:5) Jeiel (second): some read Jaaziel or Aziel, as in 15:18, 20.
- d (16:6) Jahaziel, see 12:4.
- e (16:8) Verses 8–22 parallel Psalm 105:1–15.
- f (16:13) Psalm 105:6 reads "offspring of Abraham."
- g (16:15) Psalm 105:8 reads "He has remembered his covenant forever."
- h (16:19) Psalm 105:12 reads "when they were."
- i (16:23) Verses 23–33 parallel Psalm 96:1–13, with differences.
- j (16:26) Hebrew 'elilim, "worthless things," a play on 'elohim, "gods."
- k (16:27) Psalm 96:6 reads "Strength and beauty are in his sanctuary."
- l (16:29) Or "in the splendor of holiness."
- m (16:34) Verses 34–36 parallel Psalm 106:1, 47–48. Psalm 106:47 reads "Save us, Yahweh our God."
- n (16:36) Psalm 106:48 ends "Let all the people say, 'Amen!' Praise Yah!"
- o (16:38) Jeduthun, "praising"; Hosah, "refuge." Obed-edom, see 13:13.
- p (16:39) Gibeon, "hill"; compare 21:29; 2 Chronicles 1:3.
- q (16:41) See 2 Chronicles 5:13; 7:3; Psalms 106:1; 136:1.
- r (16:43) Second Samuel 6:19–20 parallels this verse; Chronicles omits Michal's rebuke of David (2 Samuel 6:20–23).

Chapter 17

1 When David was living in his house, David said to Nathan the prophet, "Look, I live in a house of cedar, but the ark of the covenant of Yahweh is under curtains."[a] 2 Nathan said to David, "Do all that is in your heart, for God is with you."

3 But that same night the word of God came to Nathan, saying, 4 "Go and tell my servant David, 'This is what Yahweh says: You are not the one to build a house for me to live in.[b] 5 For I have not lived in a house since the day that I brought up Israel to this day, but have gone from tent to tent and from tabernacle to tabernacle.[c] 6 In all places where I have walked with all Israel, did I speak a word with any of the judges of Israel, whom I commanded to shepherd my people, saying, "Why have you not built me a house of cedar?"'[d] 7 Now therefore you

shall say to my servant David, ‘Thus says Yahweh of Armies: I took you from the pasture, from following the sheep, to be prince over my people Israel. 8 I have been with you wherever you have gone, and have cut off all your enemies from before you. And I will make you a name, like the name of the great ones who are in the earth. 9 I will appoint a place for my people Israel and will plant them, that they may dwell in their own place and be disturbed no more. The children of wickedness shall not waste them any more, as at the first, 10 and from the days that I commanded judges to be over my people Israel. And I will subdue all your enemies. Moreover I tell you that Yahweh will build you a house.[e] 11 When your days are fulfilled for you to go to be with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall be of your sons, and I will establish his kingdom. 12 He shall build me a house, and I will establish his throne forever. 13 I will be his father, and he shall be my son.[f] I will not take my steadfast love away from him, as I took it from him who was before you. 14 But I will settle him in my house and in my kingdom forever, and his throne shall be established forever.’”[g] 15 According to all these words, and according to all this vision, so Nathan spoke to David.

16 Then King David went in and sat before Yahweh and said, “Who am I, Yahweh God, and what is my house, that you have brought me this far? 17 Yet even this was too little in your sight, God. You have also spoken about the future of your servant’s house, and you have looked on me as a man of high rank,[h] Yahweh God. 18 What more can David say to you about the honor done to your servant? For you know your servant. 19 Yahweh, for your servant’s sake, and according to your own heart, you have worked all this greatness, to make known all these great things.[i] 20 Yahweh, there is no one like you, neither is there any God besides you, according to all that we have heard with our ears. 21 What one nation in the earth is like your people Israel, whom God went to redeem to be his own people, to make for yourself a name by great and awesome things, in driving out nations from before your people whom you redeemed out of Egypt? [j] 22 For you made your people Israel your own people forever; and you, Yahweh, became their God. 23 Now, Yahweh, let the word that

you have spoken concerning your servant and concerning his house be established forever, and do as you have spoken. 24 Let your name be established and magnified forever, saying, 'Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, is Israel's God'; and the house of David your servant shall be established before you. 25 For you, my God, have revealed to your servant that you will build him a house. Therefore your servant has found courage to pray before you. 26 Now, Yahweh, you are God, and you have promised this good thing to your servant. 27 Now it has pleased you to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For you, Yahweh, have blessed, and it is blessed forever."[k]

Notes

- a (17:1) Verses 1–27 parallel 2 Samuel 7:1–29. Chronicles omits "Yahweh had given him rest from all his enemies around him" (2 Samuel 7:1). Nathan, "he has given."
- b (17:4) Second Samuel 7:5 has a question: "Shall you build me a house to dwell in?"
- c (17:5) Hebrew "from tent to tent and from tabernacle"; the words "to tabernacle" are supplied from the sense. Compare 2 Samuel 7:6.
- d (17:6) Hebrew shophet, "judge"; 2 Samuel 7:7 reads shibte, "tribes," probably a copying difference.
- e (17:10) Second Samuel 7:11 reads "Yahweh will make you a house"; the house here is a dynasty.
- f (17:13) Chronicles omits 2 Samuel 7:14b, "When he commits iniquity, I will chasten him with the rod of men."
- g (17:14) Second Samuel 7:16 reads "your house and your kingdom … before you … your throne." Chronicles speaks of God's house and kingdom.
- h (17:17) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; compare 2 Samuel 7:19, "and this is the law for man."
- i (17:19) Second Samuel 7:21 reads "For your word's sake."
- j (17:21) Second Samuel 7:23 adds "from Egypt, the nations and their gods."
- k (17:27) Some witnesses read "and may it be blessed forever."

Chapter 18

1 After this David struck the Philistines and subdued them, and he took Gath and its towns out of the hand of the Philistines.[a] 2 He struck Moab, and the Moabites became servants to David and brought tribute.[b]

3 David also struck Hadarezer king of Zobah, toward Hamath, as he went to establish his dominion at the river Euphrates.[c] 4 David seized

a thousand of his chariots, seven thousand charioteers, and twenty thousand foot soldiers. David crippled all the chariot horses except enough for a hundred chariots.[d] 5 When the Syrians of Damascus came to help Hadarezer king of Zobah, David struck down twenty-two thousand men of the Syrians.[e] 6 Then David put garrisons in Syria of Damascus, and the Syrians became servants to David and brought tribute. Yahweh gave victory to David wherever he went. 7 David took the shields of gold that were on the servants of Hadarezer and brought them to Jerusalem. 8 From Tibhath and from Cun, cities of Hadarezer, David took very much bronze, with which Solomon made the bronze sea, the pillars, and the vessels of bronze.[f]

9 When Tou king of Hamath heard that David had struck all the host of Hadarezer king of Zobah,[g] 10 he sent Hadoram his son to King David to greet him and to bless him, because he had fought against Hadarezer and struck him; for Hadarezer had been at war with Tou. And he sent all kinds of vessels of gold and silver and bronze.[h] 11 These also King David dedicated to Yahweh, with the silver and the gold which he carried away from all the nations, from Edom, and from Moab, and from the sons of Ammon, and from the Philistines, and from Amalek.

12 Moreover Abishai son of Zeruiah slew of the Edomites in the Valley of Salt eighteen thousand.[i] 13 He put garrisons in Edom, and all the Edomites became servants to David. And Yahweh gave victory to David wherever he went.

14 So David reigned over all Israel, and he executed justice and righteousness for all his people. 15 Joab the son of Zeruiah was over the army; and Jehoshaphat the son of Ahilud was recorder;[j] 16 and Zadok the son of Ahitub and Abimelech the son of Abiathar were priests; and Shavsha was secretary;[k] 17 and Benaiah the son of Jehoiada was over the Cherethites and the Pelethites; and the sons of David were chief officials in the service of the king.[l]

Notes

- a (18:1) Verses 1–17 parallel 2 Samuel 8:1–18. Second Samuel 8:1 reads "took Metheg-ammah," perhaps "the bridle of the mother city." Gath, "winepress."
- b (18:2) Chronicles omits the execution of two-thirds of the Moabite captives (2 Samuel 8:2).

- c (18:3) Hadarezer, “Hadad is help” (2 Samuel 8:3 Hadadezer); Zobah, an Aramean kingdom; Euphrates, see 5:9.
- d (18:4) Second Samuel 8:4 reads “a thousand seven hundred horsemen” and does not mention the chariots; the Septuagint of Samuel agrees with Chronicles.
- e (18:5) Syrians, Hebrew “Aram”; Damascus, perhaps “well-watered.”
- f (18:8) Second Samuel 8:8 reads “Betah and Berothai” and does not mention Solomon’s use of the bronze. Tibhath, “slaughter”; Cun, perhaps “established.” On the bronze sea, see 2 Chronicles 4:2–5.
- g (18:9) Tou (2 Samuel 8:9 Toi), uncertain.
- h (18:10) Hadoram, “Hadad is exalted” (2 Samuel 8:10 Joram, “Yahweh is exalted”).
- i (18:12) Second Samuel 8:13 credits David himself (“when he returned from striking eighteen thousand Arameans,” perhaps a misreading of Edom); Psalm 60 heading credits Joab with twelve thousand. Edomites, of Edom (“red”).
- j (18:15) Jehoshaphat, “Yahweh has judged”; Ahilud, “a brother is born.”
- k (18:16) Second Samuel 8:17 reads “Ahimelech the son of Abiathar” (as do many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Vulgate here) and “Seraiah,” who is called Sheva in 2 Samuel 20:25 and Shisha in 1 Kings 4:3. Ahitub, see 6:7; Abimelech, “my father is king”; Shavsha, uncertain.
- l (18:17) Second Samuel 8:18 reads “and David’s sons were priests.” Cherethites and Pelethites, the king’s foreign guard, perhaps Cretans and Philistines.

Chapter 19

1 Some time later, Nahash king of the Ammonites died, and his son
became king in his place.[a] 2 David said, “I will show kindness to Hanun
the son of Nahash, because his father showed kindness to me.” So
David sent messengers to comfort him concerning his father. And
David’s servants came into the land of the sons of Ammon to Hanun
to comfort him.[b] 3 But the Ammonite officials told Hanun, “Do you
think David is honoring your father by sending men to console you?
Haven’t his servants come to you to explore the country, overthrow
it, and spy on it?” 4 So Hanun seized David’s servants, shaved them,
cut their clothes off at the hips, and sent them away. 5 When David
was told what had happened to the men, he sent messengers to meet
them, since they were deeply humiliated. “Wait at Jericho until your
beards grow back,” the king said, “and then come home.”[c]
6 When the sons of Ammon saw that they had made themselves
odious to David, Hanun and the sons of Ammon sent about 37
tons of silver[d] to hire chariots and horsemen for themselves from

Mesopotamia, from Aram-maacah, and from Zobah.[e] 7 So they hired
thirty-two thousand chariots, and the king of Maacah with his people,
who came and encamped before Medeba. The sons of Ammon gath-
ered themselves together from their cities and came to battle.[f] 8 When
David heard of it, he sent Joab and all the army of the mighty men. 9
The sons of Ammon came out and set the battle in array at the gate of
the city, and the kings who had come were by themselves in the field.
10 Now when Joab saw that the battle was set against him before and
behind, he chose out of all the choice men of Israel and set them in
array against the Syrians. 11 He placed the rest of the army under his
brother Abishai, and they lined up to face the Ammonites. 12 Joab said,
"If the Arameans prove too strong for me, you are to come to my aid;
and if the Ammonites prove too strong for you, I will come to yours.
13 Be of good courage, and let us be strong for our people and for the
cities of our God. And may Yahweh do what seems good to him." 14 So
Joab and the people who were with him drew near before the Syrians
to the battle, and they fled before him. 15 When the sons of Ammon
saw that the Syrians had fled, they likewise fled before Abishai his
brother and entered the city. Then Joab came to Jerusalem.
16 When the Syrians saw that they had been put to the worse before
Israel, they sent messengers and brought out the Syrians who were
beyond the River, with Shophach the captain of the host of Hadarezer
at their head.[g] 17 It was told David, and he gathered all Israel together
and crossed over the Jordan, and came upon them and set the battle in
array against them. So when David had set the battle in array against
the Syrians, they fought with him. 18 The Syrians fled before Israel,
and David killed of the Syrians the men of seven thousand chariots
and forty thousand footmen, and put to death Shophach the captain
of the host.[h] 19 When the servants of Hadarezer saw that they were put
to the worse before Israel, they made peace with David and served
him. So the Syrians would not help the sons of Ammon any more.

Notes

- a (19:1) Verses 1–19 parallel 2 Samuel 10:1–19. Nahash, "serpent"; Ammon, "people."
- b (19:2) Hanun, "favored."

- c (19:5) Jericho, perhaps "moon city."
- d (19:6) Hebrew "a thousand talents"; about 34 metric tons. Not mentioned in 2 Samuel 10:6.
- e (19:6) Hebrew Aram-naharaim, "Aram of the two rivers." Second Samuel 10:6 names Beth-rehob, Zobah, Maacah, and Tob. Maacah, see 2:48.
- f (19:7) Second Samuel 10:6 reads "twenty thousand foot soldiers … and twelve thousand men of Tob," giving the same total of thirty-two thousand, but footmen rather than chariots. Medeba, perhaps "waters of quiet."
- g (19:16) Shophach (2 Samuel 10:16 Shobach), perhaps "pouring." The River is the Euphrates.
- h (19:18) Second Samuel 10:18 reads "the men of seven hundred chariots and forty thousand horsemen."

Chapter 20

1 In the spring, when kings go out to war, Joab led out the army and ravaged the land of the Ammonites. He came to Rabbah and besieged it, but David stayed in Jerusalem. Joab attacked Rabbah and tore it down.[a] 2 David took the crown of their king from off his head,[b] and found it to weigh about 75 pounds of gold,[c] and there were precious stones in it; and it was set on David's head. He brought out the spoil of the city in great abundance. 3 He brought out the city's people and put them to work using saws, iron picks, and axes.[d] David did this to each Ammonite city. Then David and his whole army returned to Jerusalem.

4 It came to pass after this that there arose war with the Philistines at Gezer; at that time Sibbecai the Hushathite slew Sippai, of the sons of the giants;[e] and the Philistines were brought low. 5 There was again war with the Philistines, and Elhanan the son of Jair killed Lahmi the brother of Goliath the Gittite, the shaft of whose spear was like a weaver's beam.[f] 6 There was again war at Gath, where there was a man of great stature, who had twenty-four fingers and toes, six on each hand and six on each foot; and he also was descended from the giants.[g] 7 When he defied Israel, Jonathan the son of Shimea, David's brother, killed him.[h] 8 These were descended from the giants in Gath, and they fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants.

Notes

- a (20:1) Verses 1–3 parallel 2 Samuel 11:1; 12:26, 30–31. Chronicles omits the story of Bathsheba and Uriah (2 Samuel 11:2–12:25) and Joab's summons to David (2 Samuel 12:27–29). Rabbah, "great (city)."
- b (20:2) Or "the crown of Milcom," the god of the Ammonites; the Hebrew consonants malkam can be read either way.
- c (20:2) Hebrew "a talent"; about 34 kilograms.
- d (20:3) So 2 Samuel 12:31; Hebrew "and he sawed them with the saw, with iron picks, and with saws." The verb wayyasar ("and he sawed") may be a copying error for wayyasem ("and he set them").
- e (20:4) Hebrew "of the Rephaim." Second Samuel 21:18 reads "Saph" and "at Gob." Sippai, perhaps "threshold."
- f (20:5) Second Samuel 21:19 reads "Elhanan the son of Jaare-oregim, the Bethlehemite, killed Goliath the Gittite." Chronicles names Lahmi (from the last part of "the Bethlehemite") as Goliath's brother, reconciling the text with 1 Samuel 17. Jair, "he enlightens"; Lahmi, perhaps "my bread"; Goliath, uncertain.
- g (20:6) Verses 6–8 parallel 2 Samuel 21:20–22.
- h (20:7) Jonathan, see 2:32; Shimea, see 2:13.

Chapter 21

1 Satan stood up against Israel and moved David to number Israel.[a] 2
David said to Joab and to the princes of the people, "Go, count Israel
from Beersheba even to Dan; and bring me word, that I may know
their number."[b] 3 Joab replied, "May Yahweh multiply his people a
hundred times over! My lord the king, aren't they all my lord's servants? Why does my lord want this done? Why make Israel guilty?"
4 Nevertheless the king's word prevailed against Joab. Therefore Joab
departed and went throughout all Israel, and came to Jerusalem. 5 Joab
gave the sum of the numbering of the people to David. All those of
Israel were one million one hundred thousand men who drew the
sword; and in Judah were four hundred and seventy thousand men
who drew the sword.[c] 6 But he did not count Levi and Benjamin among
them, for the king's word was abhorrent to Joab.[d]
7 God was displeased with this thing, so he struck Israel. 8 David said to
God, "I have sinned greatly in doing this thing. But now, please take
away the iniquity of your servant, for I have acted very foolishly."
9 Yahweh spoke to Gad, David's seer, saying,[e] 10 "Go and speak to
David, saying, 'Thus says Yahweh: I offer you three things. Choose
one of them, that I may do it to you.'" 11 So Gad came to David and

said to him, "Thus says Yahweh: 'Take your choice: 12 three years of famine; or three months of fleeing from your enemies while their swords overtake you; or three days of Yahweh's sword, a plague in the land, with Yahweh's angel destroying across the whole territory of Israel.' Now decide what reply I should carry to the one who sent me."[f] 13 David said to Gad, "I am in great distress. Let me fall now into the hand of Yahweh, for very great are his mercies; and let me not fall into the hand of man."
14 So Yahweh sent a pestilence on Israel, and there fell of Israel seventy thousand men. 15 And God sent an angel to Jerusalem to destroy it. As he was about to destroy, Yahweh looked, and he relented of the evil, and said to the destroying angel, "It is enough; now stay your hand." The angel of Yahweh was standing by the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.[g] 16 David lifted up his eyes and saw the angel of Yahweh standing between earth and heaven, having a drawn sword in his hand stretched out over Jerusalem. Then David and the elders, clothed in sackcloth, fell on their faces.[h] 17 David said to God, "Was it not I who ordered the counting of the people? I am the one who has sinned and done terrible wrong. But what have these sheep done? Yahweh my God, let your hand strike me and my family instead, and spare your people from the plague."
18 Then the angel of Yahweh commanded Gad to say to David that David should go up and set up an altar to Yahweh on the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite. 19 David went up at the saying of Gad, which he had spoken in Yahweh's name. 20 Ornan turned back and saw the angel, and his four sons who were with him hid themselves. Now Ornan was threshing wheat.[i] 21 As David came to Ornan, Ornan looked and saw David, and went out of the threshing floor and bowed himself to David with his face to the ground. 22 Then David said to Ornan, "Give me the site of this threshing floor, that I may build on it an altar to Yahweh. You shall sell it to me for the full price, that the plague may be stopped from the people." 23 Ornan said to David, "Take it for yourself, and let my lord the king do what is good in his eyes. Look, I give the oxen for burnt offerings, and the threshing sledges for wood, and the wheat for the grain offering; I give it all."

24 King David answered Ornan, “No, I will buy it at its full price. I
refuse to take what is yours and give it to Yahweh, or to present a
burnt offering that cost me nothing.” 25 So David gave to Ornan for the
place gold weighing about fifteen pounds.[j] 26 David built an altar to
Yahweh there and presented burnt offerings and peace offerings. He
called out to Yahweh, who answered him from heaven with fire on
the altar for burnt offerings.[k] 27 Then Yahweh commanded the angel,
and he put his sword back into its sheath.
28 At that time, when David saw that Yahweh had answered him on
the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite, he sacrificed there. 29 For the
tabernacle of Yahweh, which Moses made in the wilderness, and the
altar of burnt offering, were at that time in the high place at Gibeon.
30 But David could not go before it to inquire of God, for he was afraid
because of the sword of the angel of Yahweh.

Notes

- a (21:1) Verses 1–27 parallel 2 Samuel 24:1–25. Second Samuel 24:1 says “The anger of Yahweh was kindled against Israel, and he moved David against them.” Hebrew satan, without the article, may be read as the proper name Satan or as “an adversary.”
- b (21:2) Beersheba, “well of seven” or “well of the oath”; Dan, “judge.” Chronicles omits the route of the census (2 Samuel 24:5–8).
- c (21:5) Second Samuel 24:9 reads “in Israel eight hundred thousand valiant men … and the men of Judah were five hundred thousand.” The figures cannot be fully reconciled; Chronicles may include the standing army (27:1–15) or follow a different source.
- d (21:6) This explanation is found only in Chronicles; compare Numbers 1:47–49.
- e (21:9) Gad, “fortune.”
- f (21:12) Second Samuel 24:13 reads “seven years of famine” (the Septuagint of Samuel reads “three years,” as here).
- g (21:15) Ornan (2 Samuel 24:16 Araunah), perhaps a Hurrian name or title, “lord.”
- h (21:16) This verse is not in the standard text of 2 Samuel, but a Dead Sea Scroll of Samuel (4QSam-a) has a similar verse at 2 Samuel 24:16.
- i (21:20) Second Samuel 24:20 says only that Araunah looked out and saw the king and his servants coming toward him.
- j (21:25) Hebrew “six hundred shekels of gold by weight,” about 6.9 kilograms. Second Samuel 24:24 says David bought the threshing floor and the oxen for fifty shekels of silver, about 1¼ pounds (575 grams). Chronicles speaks of the whole “place,” the future temple site.

- k (21:26) See Leviticus 9:24; 1 Kings 18:38. The fire from heaven is not mentioned in 2 Samuel.

Chapter 22

1 Then David said, "This is the house of Yahweh God, and this is the altar of burnt offering for Israel."[a]
2 David commanded to gather together the foreigners who were in the land of Israel, and he set stonecutters to cut dressed stones to build the house of God. 3 David prepared iron in abundance for the nails for the doors of the gates and for the clamps, and bronze in abundance beyond weighing, 4 and cedar trees without number; for the Sidonians and the Tyrians brought cedar trees in abundance to David.[b] 5 David said, "Solomon my son is young and tender, and the house that is to be built for Yahweh must be exceedingly magnificent, of fame and of glory throughout all countries. I will therefore make preparation for it." So David prepared abundantly before his death.
6 Then he called for Solomon his son and charged him to build a house for Yahweh, the God of Israel. 7 David said to Solomon, "My son, as for me, it was in my heart to build a house to the name of Yahweh my God. 8 But the word of Yahweh came to me, saying, 'You have shed blood abundantly and have made great wars. You shall not build a house to my name, because you have shed much blood upon the earth in my sight. 9 Behold, a son shall be born to you, who shall be a man of rest. I will give him rest from all his enemies all around; for his name shall be Solomon, and I will give peace and quietness to Israel in his days.[c] 10 He shall build a house for my name. He shall be my son, and I will be his father; and I will establish the throne of his kingdom over Israel forever.' 11 Now, my son, may Yahweh be with you, so that you may prosper and build the house of Yahweh your God, as he has spoken concerning you. 12 May Yahweh give you wisdom and understanding as he makes you ruler over Israel, so that you will keep the law of Yahweh your God. 13 Then you will prosper, if you are careful to do the statutes and the ordinances which Yahweh commanded Moses concerning Israel. Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid, nor be dismayed. 14 Now see, in my affliction I have

prepared for the house of Yahweh about 3,750 tons of gold and 37,500 tons of silver,[d] and bronze and iron beyond weighing, for it is in abundance. I have also prepared timber and stone, and you may add to them. 15 There are also workmen with you in abundance, cutters and workers of stone and timber, and all kinds of men who are skillful in every kind of work. 16 There is no counting the gold, silver, bronze, and iron. Get up and begin the work, and may Yahweh be with you." 17 David also commanded all the princes of Israel to help Solomon his son, saying, 18 "Is not Yahweh your God with you? And has he not given you rest on every side? For he has delivered the inhabitants of the land into my hand, and the land is subdued before Yahweh and before his people. 19 Now set your heart and your soul to seek Yahweh your God. Arise therefore and build the sanctuary of Yahweh God, to bring the ark of the covenant of Yahweh and the holy vessels of God into the house that is to be built for the name of Yahweh."

Notes

- a (22:1) This verse identifies Ornan's threshing floor as the site of the temple; compare 2 Chronicles 3:1.
- b (22:4) Sidonians, of Sidon ("fishing"); Tyrians, of Tyre (14:1).
- c (22:9) Solomon (Hebrew Shelomoh) sounds like shalom, "peace."
- d (22:14) Hebrew "a hundred thousand talents of gold and a million talents of silver": about 3,750 tons (3,400 metric tons) of gold and 37,500 tons (34,000 metric tons) of silver. The figures are enormous, perhaps intentionally hyperbolic; compare 29:4, 7.

Chapter 23

1 When David was old and full of days, he made Solomon his son king over Israel.[a] 2 And he assembled all the princes of Israel, and the priests and the Levites. 3 The Levites were numbered from thirty years old and upward, and their number, counted head by head, was thirty-eight thousand men.[b] 4 "Of these," David said, "twenty-four thousand shall oversee the work of the house of Yahweh, six thousand shall be officers and judges, 5 four thousand shall be gatekeepers, and four thousand shall praise Yahweh with the instruments that I made for praise."[c] 6 David divided them into divisions corresponding to the sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.

7 Of the Gershonites: Ladan and Shimei.[d] 8 The sons of Ladan: Jehiel
the chief, and Zetham, and Joel, three.[e] 9 The sons of Shimei: Shelo-
moth, Haziel, and Haran, three. These were the heads of the fathers'
houses of Ladan.[f] 10 And the sons of Shimei: Jahath, Zina, Jeush, and
Beriah. These four were the sons of Shimei.[g] 11 Jahath was the chief,
and Zizah the second; Jeush and Beriah, however, had few sons, and
therefore they were reckoned as one father's house, one assignment.[h]
12 The sons of Kohath: Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel, four. 13 The
sons of Amram: Aaron and Moses. And Aaron was separated, that
he should sanctify the most holy things, he and his sons forever, to
burn incense before Yahweh, to minister to him, and to bless in his
name forever. 14 But as for Moses the man of God, his sons were
named among the tribe of Levi. 15 The sons of Moses: Gershom and
Eliezer. 16 The sons of Gershom: Shebuel the chief.[i] 17 The sons of
Eliezer: Rehabiah the chief. Eliezer had no other sons, but the sons of
Rehabiah were very many.[j] 18 The sons of Izhar: Shelomith the chief.[k]
19 The sons of Hebron: Jeriah the chief, Amariah the second, Jahaziel
the third, and Jekameam the fourth.[l] 20 The sons of Uzziel: Micah the
chief, and Isshiah the second.[m]
21 The sons of Merari: Mahli and Mushi. The sons of Mahli: Eleazar
and Kish. 22 Eleazar died having no sons, only daughters; and their
kinsmen, the sons of Kish, married them. 23 The sons of Mushi: Mahli,
Eder, and Jeremoth, three.[n]
24 These were the sons of Levi after their fathers' houses, even the
heads of the fathers' houses of those who were enrolled, by the
number of names counted head by head, who did the work for the
service of the house of Yahweh, from twenty years old and upward.[o]
25 For David said, "Yahweh, the God of Israel, has given rest to his
people, and he dwells in Jerusalem forever. 26 So the Levites will no
longer need to carry the tabernacle or any of its vessels for its service."
27 For by the last words of David the sons of Levi were numbered from
twenty years old and upward. 28 Their office was to be at the side of
the sons of Aaron for the service of the house of Yahweh, in the courts
and in the chambers, in the cleansing of everything holy, and in any
work for the service of the house of God; 29 also for the showbread, for

the fine flour for a grain offering, for the unleavened wafers, for the baked offering, for the offering mixed with oil, and for all measures of quantity and size. 30 They were to stand every morning to thank and praise Yahweh, and likewise at evening, 31 and whenever burnt offerings were presented to Yahweh on Sabbaths, at new moons, and at the festivals, in the numbers prescribed for them, always before Yahweh. 32 So they took responsibility for the tent of meeting and the holy place, and for assisting their relatives, Aaron's descendants, in serving Yahweh's house.

Notes

- a (23:1) Compare 1 Kings 1:1–40, where Solomon is made king amid a struggle for succession; Chronicles does not narrate that struggle.
- b (23:3) Numbers 4:3 sets the age at thirty; Numbers 8:24 at twenty-five. In verses 24 and 27 of this chapter the age is twenty, as in 2 Chronicles 31:17 and Ezra 3:8. Verse 27 explains the change as David's last instruction.
- c (23:5) Hebrew "that I made"; the Septuagint reads "that he made."
- d (23:7) Ladan (6:17 and Exodus 6:17 Libni), perhaps "for pleasure"; Shimei, see 4:26.
- e (23:8) Jehiel, see 15:18; Zetham, "olive tree"; Joel, see 4:35.
- f (23:9) Some think Shimei here should be Jehiel, as Shimei's sons follow in verse 10. Shelomoth, "peaceful"; Haziel, "God sees"; Haran, perhaps "mountaineer."
- g (23:10) Jahath, see 4:2; Zina (verse 11 Zizah; the Septuagint reads Ziza here), uncertain; Jeush, see 1:35; Beriah, see 7:23.
- h (23:11) Or "a single class for duty."
- i (23:16) Shebuel (24:20 Shubael), perhaps "return, O God." Gershom, see 6:16.
- j (23:17) Rehabiah, "Yahweh has enlarged"; Eliezer, see 15:24.
- k (23:18) Shelomith (24:22 Shelomoth), "peaceful."
- l (23:19) Jeriah, "Yahweh sees"; Amariah, see 6:7; Jahaziel, see 12:4; Jekameam, "may the people rise."
- m (23:20) Micah, see 5:5; Isshiah, see 12:6.
- n (23:23) Mahli, see 6:19; Eder, "flock"; Jeremoth, "heights."
- o (23:24) See note on verse 3.

Chapter 24

1 The divisions of the sons of Aaron were these. The sons of Aaron: Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar.[a] 2 But Nadab and Abihu died before their father and had no children, so Eleazar and Ithamar served as priests.[b] 3 David, with Zadok of the sons of Eleazar and Ahimelech of the sons of Ithamar, divided them according to their offices in their

service.[c] 4 More leaders were found among Eleazar's descendants than
among Ithamar's, so they were organized this way: sixteen family
heads from Eleazar's descendants and eight from Ithamar's, by their
families. 5 They divided them by lot, the one sort with the other; for
there were officers of the sanctuary and officers of God both of the
sons of Eleazar and of the sons of Ithamar. 6 Shemaiah the son of
Nethanel the scribe, one of the Levites, recorded them in the presence
of the king, the princes, Zadok the priest, Ahimelech the son of
Abiathar, and the heads of the fathers' houses of the priests and of the
Levites: one father's house being drawn for Eleazar, and one drawn
for Ithamar.[d]
7 The first lot came forth to Jehoiarib, the second to Jedaiah,[e] 8 the
third to Harim, the fourth to Seorim,[f] 9 the fifth to Malchijah, the sixth
to Mijamin,[g] 10 the seventh to Hakkoz, the eighth to Abijah,[h] 11 the
ninth to Jeshua, the tenth to Shecaniah,[i] 12 the eleventh to Eliashib,
the twelfth to Jakim,[j] 13 the thirteenth to Huppah, the fourteenth to
Jeshebeab,[k] 14 the fifteenth to Bilgah, the sixteenth to Immer,[l] 15 the
seventeenth to Hezir, the eighteenth to Happizzez,[m] 16 the nineteenth
to Pethahiah, the twentieth to Jehezkel,[n] 17 the twenty-first to Jachin,
the twenty-second to Gamul,[o] 18 the twenty-third to Delaiah, the
twenty-fourth to Maaziah.[p] 19 This was the order of their service
for entering Yahweh's house, following the procedure set for them
by their ancestor Aaron, just as Yahweh, the God of Israel, had
commanded him.
20 And of the rest of the sons of Levi: of the sons of Amram, Shubael; of
the sons of Shubael, Jehdeiah.[q] 21 Of Rehabiah: of the sons of Rehabiah,
Isshiah the chief. 22 Of the Izharites, Shelomoth; of the sons of Shelo-
moth, Jahath. 23 The sons of Hebron:[r] Jeriah the chief, Amariah the
second, Jahaziel the third, Jekameam the fourth. 24 The sons of Uzziel,
Micah; of the sons of Micah, Shamir.[s] 25 The brother of Micah, Isshiah;
of the sons of Isshiah, Zechariah. 26 The sons of Merari: Mahli and
Mushi. The sons of Jaaziah: Beno.[t] 27 The sons of Merari: of Jaaziah,
Beno, Shoham, Zaccur, and Ibri.[u] 28 Of Mahli: Eleazar, who had no
sons. 29 Of Kish, the sons of Kish: Jerahmeel.[v] 30 The sons of Mushi:
Mahli, Eder, and Jerimoth. These were the sons of the Levites by their

fathers' houses. [31] These likewise cast lots even as their brothers the sons of Aaron, in the presence of David the king, Zadok, Ahimelech, and the heads of the fathers' houses of the priests and of the Levites, the head of each father's house the same as his younger brother.

Notes

- a (24:1) Nadab, see 2:28; Abihu, "he is my father"; Eleazar, see 6:3; Ithamar, "island of palms."
- b (24:2) See Leviticus 10:1–2.
- c (24:3) Ahimelech, "my brother is king." Compare 18:16, where the Hebrew reads Abimelech.
- d (24:6) Hebrew "one father's house taken for Eleazar, and taken, taken for Ithamar"; the Septuagint reads "one to Eleazar, and one to Ithamar." Shemaiah, see 3:22; Nethanel, see 2:14.
- e (24:7) Jehoiarib (9:10 Jehoiarib), "Yahweh contends"; Jedaiah, see 4:37. The Maccabees were of the course of Jehoiarib (1 Maccabees 2:1).
- f (24:8) Harim, "consecrated"; Seorim, "barley."
- g (24:9) Malchijah, "Yahweh is king"; Mijamin, "from the right hand."
- h (24:10) Hakkoz, "the thorn"; Abijah, "Yahweh is father." Zechariah the father of John the Baptist belonged to the division of Abijah (Luke 1:5).
- i (24:11) Jeshua, "Yahweh is salvation"; Shecaniah, "Yahweh has dwelt."
- j (24:12) Eliashib, see 3:24; Jakim, see 8:19.
- k (24:13) Huppah, "canopy"; Jeshebeab, perhaps "father's dwelling."
- l (24:14) Bilgah, "cheerfulness"; Immer, "lamb."
- m (24:15) Hezir, "swine"; Happizzez, "the shattering."
- n (24:16) Pethahiah, "Yahweh opens"; Jehezkel, "God strengthens" (the same name as Ezekiel).
- o (24:17) Jachin, "he establishes"; Gamul, "weaned."
- p (24:18) Delaiah, see 3:24; Maaziah, "Yahweh is a refuge."
- q (24:20) Shubael, see 23:16; Jehdeiah, "Yahweh rejoices."
- r (24:23) "Of Hebron" and "the chief" are supplied from 23:19; the Hebrew reads "And my sons: Jeriah."
- s (24:24) So the Hebrew margin (Qere); the written text (Ketiv) reads Shamur. Shamir, "thorn."
- t (24:26) Jaaziah, "Yahweh strengthens"; Beno, "his son." The Hebrew of verses 26–27 is uncertain; beno may mean "his son" rather than a name.
- u (24:27) Shoham, "onyx"; Zaccur, see 4:26; Ibri, "Hebrew."
- v (24:29) Jerahmeel, see 2:9; Kish, see 23:21.

Chapter 25

1 David and the army commanders also set aside for service some
of the descendants of Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, who were to
prophesy with the music of lyres, harps, and cymbals. The list of
men who did this service was:[a] 2 Of the sons of Asaph: Zaccur,
Joseph, Nethaniah, and Asharelah, the sons of Asaph, under the hand
of Asaph, who prophesied at the king's order.[b] 3 Of Jeduthun, the
sons of Jeduthun: Gedaliah, Zeri, Jeshaiah, Shimei,[c] Hashabiah, and
Mattithiah, six, under the direction of their father Jeduthun, who
prophesied with the lyre in giving thanks and praising Yahweh.[d] 4 Of
Heman, the sons of Heman: Bukkiah, Mattaniah, Uzziel, Shebuel, and
Jerimoth, Hananiah, Hanani, Eliathah, Giddalti, and Romamti-ezer,
Joshbekashah, Mallothi, Hothir, and Mahazioth.[e] 5 All these were sons
of Heman, the king's seer in the words of God, to lift up his horn;[f] and
God gave Heman fourteen sons and three daughters. 6 They were all
under the direction of their father for song in the house of Yahweh
with cymbals, harps, and lyres, for the service of the house of God.
Asaph, Jeduthun, and Heman were under the direction of the king.
7 Their number, with their brothers who were trained in singing to
Yahweh, all who were skilled, was two hundred and eighty-eight. 8
They cast lots for their duties, small and great alike, teacher as well
as pupil.
9 The first lot fell for Asaph to Joseph;[g] the second to Gedaliah, he
and his brothers and his sons, twelve; 10 the third to Zaccur, his
sons and his brothers, twelve; 11 the fourth to Izri, his sons and his
brothers, twelve;[h] 12 the fifth to Nethaniah, his sons and his brothers,
twelve; 13 the sixth to Bukkiah, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 14
the seventh to Jesharelah, his sons and his brothers, twelve;[i] 15 the
eighth to Jeshaiah, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 16 the ninth to
Mattaniah, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 17 the tenth to Shimei,
his sons and his brothers, twelve; 18 the eleventh to Azarel, his sons
and his brothers, twelve;[j] 19 the twelfth to Hashabiah, his sons and his
brothers, twelve; 20 the thirteenth, Shubael, his sons and his brothers,
twelve;[k] 21 the fourteenth, Mattithiah, his sons and his brothers,
twelve; 22 the fifteenth, to Jeremoth, his sons and his brothers, twelve;[l]

23 the sixteenth, to Hananiah, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 24
the seventeenth, to Joshbekashah, his sons and his brothers, twelve;
25 the eighteenth, to Hanani, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 26
the nineteenth, to Mallothi, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 27 the
twentieth, to Eliathah, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 28 the twenty-
first, to Hothir, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 29 the twenty-second,
to Giddalti, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 30 the twenty-third, to
Mahazioth, his sons and his brothers, twelve; 31 the twenty-fourth, to
Romamti-ezer, his sons and his brothers, twelve.[m]

Notes

- a (25:1) Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, see 6:33, 39; 16:41. Here their music is called prophecy (compare 2 Kings 3:15).
- b (25:2) Zaccur, see 4:26; Joseph, "may he add"; Nethaniah, "Yahweh has given"; Asharelah (verse 14 Jesharelah), perhaps "upright toward God."
- c (25:3) Shimei is supplied from verse 17; the Hebrew and the Septuagint list five names but say "six."
- d (25:3) Gedaliah, "Yahweh is great"; Zeri (verse 11 Izri), perhaps "balm"; Jeshaiah, "Yahweh saves"; Hashabiah, see 6:45; Mattithiah, see 9:31.
- e (25:4) Bukkiah, "flask of Yahweh"; Mattaniah, see 9:15; Uzziel, see 4:42; Shebuel (verse 20 Shubael), see 23:16; Jerimoth (verse 22 Jeremoth), see 7:7; Hananiah, "Yahweh is gracious"; Hanani, "gracious." The remaining names, read together, form a short prayer: "Be gracious to me, Yah, be gracious to me; you are my God (Eliathah); I have magnified (Giddalti) and I have exalted (Romamti) help (ezer); sitting in hardship (Joshbekashah), I have spoken (Mallothi); he has given abundantly (Hothir) visions (Mahazioth)."
- f (25:5) Hebrew "to lift up the horn," an idiom for giving strength or honor.
- g (25:9) The Hebrew gives no number for Joseph; the total of 288 (verse 7) implies twelve for each of the twenty-four lots.
- h (25:11) Izri, see Zeri, verse 3.
- i (25:14) Jesharelah, see verse 2 (Asharelah).
- j (25:18) Azarel (verse 4 Uzziel), see 12:6.
- k (25:20) Shubael, see verse 4 (Shebuel).
- l (25:22) Jeremoth, see verse 4 (Jerimoth).
- m (25:31) The twenty-four musical courses parallel the twenty-four priestly courses of chapter 24.

Chapter 26

1 As for the divisions of the gatekeepers: of the Korahites,
Meshelemiah the son of Kore, of the sons of Asaph.[a] 2 Meshelemiah

had sons: Zechariah the firstborn, Jediael the second, Zebadiah the third, Jathniel the fourth,[b] 3 Elam the fifth, Jehohanan the sixth, Eliehoenai the seventh.[c] 4 Obed-edom had sons: Shemaiah the firstborn, Jehozabad the second, Joah the third, Sachar the fourth, Nethanel the fifth,[d] 5 Ammiel the sixth, Issachar the seventh, Peullethai the eighth; for God blessed him.[e] 6 Also to Shemaiah his son were sons born who ruled over their fathers' house, for they were mighty men of valor. 7 The sons of Shemaiah were Othni, and Rephael, and Obed, and Elzabad, whose brothers were strong men, Elihu, and Semachiah.[f] 8 All these were of the sons of Obed-edom; they and their sons and their brothers were able men with strength for the service, sixty-two of Obed-edom. 9 Meshelemiah had sons and brothers, able men, eighteen. 10 Hosah, of the sons of Merari, had sons: Shimri the chief (for though he was not the firstborn, his father made him chief),[g] 11 Hilkiah the second, Tebaliah the third, Zechariah the fourth. All the sons and brothers of Hosah were thirteen.[h]

12 Of these were the divisions of the gatekeepers, by their chief men, having charges like their brothers, to minister in the house of Yahweh. 13 They cast lots, small and great alike, by their fathers' houses, for each gate. 14 Eastward the lot fell to Shelemiah. Then for Zechariah his son, a wise counselor, they cast lots, and his lot came out northward.[i] 15 To Obed-edom southward, and to his sons the storehouse.[j] 16 To Shuppim and Hosah westward, by the gate of Shallecheth, at the causeway going up, guard beside guard.[k] 17 Eastward were six Levites, northward four a day, southward four a day, and for the storehouse two and two. 18 For the Parbar westward, four at the causeway and two at the Parbar.[l] 19 These were the divisions of the doorkeepers, of the sons of the Korahites and of the sons of Merari.

20 Of the Levites, Ahijah was over the treasures of the house of God and over the treasures of the dedicated things.[m] 21 The sons of Ladan, the sons of the Gershonites belonging to Ladan, the heads of the fathers' houses belonging to Ladan the Gershonite: Jehieli.[n] 22 The sons of Jehieli: Zetham, and Joel his brother, over the treasures of the house of Yahweh. 23 Of the Amramites, the Izharites, the Hebronites, and the Uzzielites: 24 Shebuel the son of Gershom, the son of Moses, was ruler

over the treasures. 25 His brothers: from Eliezer came Rehabiah his son, and Jeshaiah his son, and Joram his son, and Zichri his son, and Shelomoth his son.[o] 26 This Shelomoth and his brothers were over all the treasures of the dedicated things which King David and the heads of the fathers' houses, the officers of thousands and of hundreds, and the commanders of the army had dedicated.[p] 27 Out of the spoil taken in the wars they dedicated things to strengthen the house of Yahweh. 28 Also all that Samuel the seer, and Saul the son of Kish, and Abner the son of Ner, and Joab the son of Zeruiah had dedicated, everything dedicated was in the care of Shelomoth and his brothers.[q]
29 Of the Izharites, Chenaniah and his sons were appointed to outside duties over Israel, as officers and judges.[r] 30 From the Hebronites: Hashabiah and 1,700 of his relatives, capable men, were responsible for Israel west of the Jordan in all of Yahweh's work and in the king's service.[s] 31 Of the Hebronites, Jerijah was chief of the Hebronites, according to their generations by fathers' houses. In the fortieth year of the reign of David they were sought out, and mighty men of valor were found among them at Jazer of Gilead.[t] 32 King David appointed him and his brothers, two thousand seven hundred able men, heads of fathers' houses, over the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of the Manassites, for every matter pertaining to God and for the affairs of the king.

Notes

- a (26:1) Meshelemiah (verse 14 Shelemiah; 9:21), "Yahweh repays"; Kore, see 9:19. "Asaph" is perhaps a copying error for Ebiasaph (9:19).
- b (26:2) Zechariah, see 9:21; Jediael, see 7:6; Zebadiah, see 8:15; Jathniel, "God gives."
- c (26:3) Elam, see 8:24; Jehohanan, "Yahweh is gracious"; Eliehoenai, "my eyes are toward Yahweh."
- d (26:4) Obed-edom, see 13:13; Shemaiah, see 3:22; Jehozabad, "Yahweh has given"; Joah, see 6:21; Sachar, see 11:35; Nethanel, see 2:14.
- e (26:5) Ammiel, see 3:5; Issachar, see 12:32; Peullethai, "wage of Yahweh." The blessing recalls 13:14.
- f (26:7) Othni, perhaps "my strength"; Rephael, "God heals"; Obed, see 2:12; Elzabad, see 12:12; Elihu, see 12:20; Semachiah, "Yahweh sustains."
- g (26:10) Hosah, see 16:38; Shimri, see 4:37.
- h (26:11) Hilkiah, see 6:13; Tebaliah, "Yahweh has immersed."

- i (26:14) Shelemiah, see verse 1.
- j (26:15) Hebrew "the house of the gatherings," a storehouse.
- k (26:16) The Hebrew "Shuppim" may be a copying repetition of the last word of verse 15. Shallecheth, "casting out."
- l (26:18) Parbar, perhaps "colonnade" or "court"; the meaning is uncertain.
- m (26:20) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "their brothers." Ahijah, see 2:25.
- n (26:21) Jehieli, a family name from Jehiel (23:8).
- o (26:25) Joram, "Yahweh is exalted"; Zichri, see 8:19.
- p (26:26) Shelomoth (Hebrew written text Shelomith), see 23:9.
- q (26:28) Abner, "father of light"; Ner, see 8:33. Samuel, "name of God" or "heard by God."
- r (26:29) Chenaniah, see 15:22.
- s (26:30) Hashabiah, see 6:45. Hebrew "beyond the Jordan westward," as seen from the east; that is, west of the Jordan.
- t (26:31) Jerijah (23:19 Jeriah), "Yahweh sees"; Jazer, "he helps."

Chapter 27

1 Here is the roster of the Israelites: the heads of families, the
commanders of thousands and of hundreds, and their officers who
served the king in everything about the divisions that were on duty
month by month through the whole year. Each division had 24,000
men:[a] 2 Over the first division for the first month (in March–April)
was Jashobeam the son of Zabdiel; in his division were twenty-four
thousand.[b] 3 He was of the children of Perez, the head of all the cap-
tains of the host for the first month. 4 Over the division of the second
month (in April–May) was Dodai the Ahohite, with his division, and
Mikloth was the leader; in his division were twenty-four thousand.[c]
5 The third army commander, for the third month (May–June), was
Benaiah son of Jehoiada the priest, the chief. His division had 24,000.[d] 6
This Benaiah was a warrior among the Thirty and was in command of
the Thirty. His division was led by his son Ammizabad.[e] 7 The fourth
commander, for the fourth month (June–July), was Joab's brother
Asahel, and after him his son Zebadiah. His division had 24,000.[f] 8 The
fifth commander, for the fifth month (in July–August), was Shamhuth
the Izrahite; in his division were twenty-four thousand.[g] 9 The sixth
commander, for the sixth month (August–September), was Ira son of
Ikkesh from Tekoa. His division had 24,000. 10 The seventh comman-
der, for the seventh month (September–October), was Helez from

Pelon, a descendant of Ephraim. His division had 24,000. 11 The eighth
commander, for the eighth month (October–November), was Sibbecai
from Hushah, a Zerahite. His division had 24,000.[h] 12 The ninth, for the
ninth month (in November–December), was Abiezer the Anathothite,
of the Benjaminites; in his division were twenty-four thousand. 13
The tenth, for the tenth month (in December–January), was Maharai
the Netophathite, of the Zerahites; in his division were twenty-four
thousand. 14 The eleventh commander, for the eleventh month (Janu-
ary–February), was Benaiah from Pirathon, a descendant of Ephraim.
His division had 24,000. 15 The twelfth commander, for the twelfth
month (February–March), was Heldai from Netophah, of the family
of Othniel. His division had 24,000.[i]
16 Furthermore, over the tribes of Israel: of the Reubenites, Eliezer
the son of Zichri was ruler; of the Simeonites, Shephatiah the son of
Maacah;[j] 17 of Levi, Hashabiah the son of Kemuel; of Aaron, Zadok;[k]
18 of Judah, Elihu, of the brothers of David; of Issachar, Omri the son
of Michael;[l] 19 of Zebulun, Ishmaiah the son of Obadiah; of Naphtali,
Jerimoth the son of Azriel;[m] 20 of the sons of Ephraim, Hoshea the son
of Azaziah; of the half-tribe of Manasseh, Joel the son of Pedaiah;[n]
21 of the half-tribe of Manasseh in Gilead, Iddo the son of Zechariah;
of Benjamin, Jaasiel the son of Abner;[o] 22 of Dan, Azarel the son of
Jeroham. These were the princes of the tribes of Israel.[p] 23 David did
not count those who were twenty years old or younger, since Yahweh
had promised to make Israel as numerous as the stars in the sky. 24
Joab the son of Zeruiah began to count them, but did not finish; and
for this there came wrath on Israel; neither was the number put into
the account of the chronicles of King David.[q]
25 Over the king's treasuries was Azmaveth the son of Adiel; and over
the storehouses in the country, in the cities, in the villages, and in
the towers was Jonathan the son of Uzziah.[r] 26 Over those who did the
work of the field, tilling the ground, was Ezri the son of Chelub.[s] 27
Shimei from Ramah was over the vineyards, and Zabdi from Shepham
was in charge of the wine stored from the vineyards.[t] 28 Baal-hanan
from Geder was in charge of the olive and sycamore-fig trees in the
foothills, and Joash was in charge of the oil supplies.[u] 29 Over the herds

that grazed in Sharon was Shitrai the Sharonite; and over the herds in the valleys was Shaphat the son of Adlai.[v] 30 Obil the Ishmaelite was in charge of the camels, and Jehdeiah from Meronoth was in charge of the donkeys.[w] 31 Jaziz the Hagrite was in charge of the flocks. All these were officials over King David's property.[x]

32 Jonathan, David's uncle, was a counselor, a man of understanding and a scribe; and Jehiel the son of Hachmoni attended the king's sons.[y] 33 Ahithophel was the king's counselor, and Hushai the Archite was the king's friend.[z] 34 After Ahithophel came Jehoiada the son of Benaiah, and Abiathar; and Joab was commander of the king's army.[aa]

Notes

- a (27:1) The months in this chapter are numbered from the spring new year (Nisan); because the calendar was lunar, each month spans parts of two of ours.
- b (27:2) Jashobeam, see 11:11; Zabdiel, "gift of God." Perez, see 2:4.
- c (27:4) Hebrew "Dodai the Ahohite and his division, and Mikloth the leader"; perhaps read "Eleazar the son of Dodai" (11:12). Dodai, "beloved"; Mikloth, see 8:32.
- d (27:5) Or "the son of Jehoiada, the chief priest." Benaiah, see 11:22.
- e (27:6) Ammizabad, "my people has given."
- f (27:7) Asahel was killed by Abner before David reigned over all Israel (2 Samuel 2:23), so this list may reflect a time when his son Zebadiah held the post in his name.
- g (27:8) Shamhuth, perhaps "desolation" (11:27 Shammoth the Harorite); Izrahite, perhaps a Zerahite of Judah.
- h (27:11) Zerahites, of Zerah (2:4).
- i (27:15) Heldai (11:30 Heled), "mole" or "enduring"; Othniel, "lion of God" or "God is my strength."
- j (27:16) Eliezer, see 15:24; Zichri, see 8:19; Shephatiah, see 3:3; Maacah, see 2:48. Gad and Asher are not listed; Levi and Aaron are counted separately.
- k (27:17) Kemuel, "God raises up."
- l (27:18) The Septuagint reads Eliab, David's eldest brother (2:13). Elihu, see 12:20; Omri, see 7:8; Michael, see 5:13.
- m (27:19) Ishmaiah, see 12:4; Obadiah, see 12:9; Jerimoth, see 7:7; Azriel, see 5:24.
- n (27:20) Hoshea, "salvation"; Azaziah, see 15:21; Pedaiah, see 3:18.
- o (27:21) Iddo, see 6:21; Jaasiel, see 11:47; Abner, see 26:28.
- p (27:22) Azarel, see 12:6; Jeroham, see 6:27.
- q (27:24) See chapter 21. "Chronicles" here is Hebrew "the account of the days."
- r (27:25) Adiel, see 4:36; Uzziah, "Yahweh is strength."
- s (27:26) Ezri, "my help"; Chelub, see 4:11.

- t (27:27) Ramathite, of Ramah (“height”); Zabdi, see 8:19; Shiphmite, perhaps of Shepham (Numbers 34:10).
- u (27:28) Shephelah, “lowland,” the foothills west of Judah. Baal-hanan, “the Lord is gracious”; Gederite, of Geder; Joash, see 12:3.
- v (27:29) Sharon, “plain”; Shitrai, perhaps “officer”; Shaphat, see 3:22; Adlai, uncertain.
- w (27:30) Obil, “camel driver”; Ishmaelite, of Ishmael (“God hears”); Jehdeiah, see 24:20; Meronothite, of Meronoth.
- x (27:31) Jaziz, perhaps “he moves”; Hagrite, see 5:10.
- y (27:32) Or “nephew”; Hebrew dod, “uncle” or “beloved.” Jonathan, see 2:32; Jehiel, see 15:18; Hachmoni, “wise.”
- z (27:33) Ahithophel, “brother of folly”; Hushai, “quick”; Archite, of the Archites (Joshua 16:2). See 2 Samuel 15:12, 32–37.
- aa (27:34) Jehoiada, see 11:22; Abiathar, see 15:11; Joab, see 2:16.

Chapter 28

1 David summoned to Jerusalem all of Israel’s officials: the tribal
leaders, the commanders of the divisions serving the king, the com-
manders of thousands and of hundreds, and those in charge of all
the king’s and his sons’ property and livestock, as well as the palace
officials, the warriors, and every brave fighter. 2 Then David the king
stood up on his feet and said, “Hear me, my brothers and my people!
As for me, it was in my heart to build a house of rest for the ark of the
covenant of Yahweh, and for the footstool of our God, and I had made
ready to build it.[a] 3 But God told me, ‘You will not build a house for
my name, since you are a warrior and have shed blood.’ 4 Yet Yahweh,
the God of Israel, selected me from my whole family to be king over
Israel for all time. He chose Judah as leader, and from Judah’s clan he
chose my father’s family; and among my father’s sons, he was pleased
to make me king over all of Israel. 5 And of all my sons (for Yahweh
has given me many sons) he has chosen Solomon my son to sit on
the throne of the kingdom of Yahweh over Israel.[b] 6 He said to me,
‘Solomon your son, he shall build my house and my courts; for I have
chosen him to be my son, and I will be his father. 7 I will establish his
kingdom forever, if he is constant to do my commandments and my
ordinances, as at this day.’ 8 Now therefore, in the sight of all Israel,
the assembly of Yahweh, and in the hearing of our God, keep and

seek out all the commandments of Yahweh your God, that you may possess this good land and leave it as an inheritance to your children after you forever.
9 "You, Solomon my son, know the God of your father, and serve him with a perfect heart and with a willing mind; for Yahweh searches all hearts and understands every purpose of the thoughts. If you seek him, he will be found of you; but if you forsake him, he will cast you off forever. 10 Take heed now, for Yahweh has chosen you to build a house for the sanctuary. Be strong and do it."
11 Then David gave his son Solomon the plans for the temple porch, its buildings, its storerooms, its upper rooms, its inner rooms, and the room for the atonement cover;[c] 12 and the pattern of all that he had in mind[d] for the courts of the house of Yahweh, for all the chambers around, for the treasuries of the house of God, and for the treasuries of the dedicated things; 13 also for the divisions of the priests and the Levites, for all the work of the service of the house of Yahweh, and for all the vessels of service in the house of Yahweh; 14 of gold by weight for all the vessels of gold for every kind of service, and of silver by weight for all the vessels of silver for every kind of service; 15 the weight of gold for the lampstands and their lamps of gold, by the weight of each lampstand and its lamps; and for the lampstands of silver, silver by weight for each lampstand and its lamps, according to the use of each lampstand; 16 and the weight of gold for each of the tables for the bread of the Presence, and silver for the silver tables; 17 and pure gold for the forks, the basins, and the cups; and for the golden bowls, gold by weight for each bowl; and for the silver bowls, silver by weight for each bowl; 18 and for the altar of incense, refined gold by weight; and gold for the pattern of the chariot, the cherubim that spread their wings and covered the ark of the covenant of Yahweh.[e] 19 "All this," said David, "he made clear to me in writing from the hand of Yahweh, all the works of this pattern."[f]
20 Then David said to Solomon his son, "Be strong and courageous, and do it. Do not be afraid or dismayed, for Yahweh God, my God, is with you. He will not leave you nor forsake you, until all the work for the service of the house of Yahweh is completed. 21 Behold, there are

the divisions of the priests and the Levites for all the service of the house of God; and there shall be with you in all kinds of work every willing, skillful man, for any manner of service; also the captains and all the people will be entirely at your command."

Notes

- a (28:2) The ark as God's footstool: compare Psalms 99:5; 132:7.
- b (28:5) The kingdom is called "the kingdom of Yahweh"; compare 17:14; 29:23.
- c (28:11) Hebrew "the house of the covering" (kapporet), the gold lid of the ark (Exodus 25:17–22).
- d (28:12) Hebrew "that was with him by the spirit," or "that he had by the Spirit."
- e (28:18) The cherubim are pictured as God's chariot throne; compare Ezekiel 1; 10.
- f (28:19) Or "All this he made clear to me in writing, because the hand of Yahweh was upon me." The Hebrew is difficult.

Chapter 29

1 King David said to all the assembly, "Solomon my son, whom alone God has chosen, is young and inexperienced, and the work is great; for the palace is not for man but for Yahweh God.[a] 2 With all my strength I have provided for the house of my God: gold for the gold objects, silver for the silver, bronze for the bronze, iron for the iron, and wood for the wooden objects; and also onyx, stones for setting, antimony and stones of many colors, every kind of precious stone, and large amounts of marble.[b] 3 Moreover, because I delight in the house of my God, I have a treasure of my own of gold and silver, and I give it to the house of my God, over and above all that I have provided for the holy house: 4 about 112 tons of gold, of the gold of Ophir, and about 262 tons of refined silver, for overlaying the walls of the houses,[c] 5 gold for gold objects and silver for silver objects, and for all the work the craftsmen will do. Now who is willing to give himself today to Yahweh by contributing?"[d]

6 Then the family heads, the tribal leaders of Israel, the commanders of thousands and of hundreds, and the officials in charge of the king's work gave willingly. 7 They gave for the service of the house of God about 188 tons of gold and about 185 pounds in gold coins,[e] about 375 tons of silver, about 675 tons of bronze, and about 3,750 tons of iron.[f] 8 Anyone who owned precious stones gave them to the treasury

of Yahweh's house, under the care of Jehiel the Gershonite.[g] 9 Then
the people rejoiced, for they offered willingly, because with a perfect
heart they offered willingly to Yahweh. David the king also rejoiced
with great joy.
10 Therefore David blessed Yahweh in the presence of all the assembly,
and David said: "Blessed are you, Yahweh, the God of Israel our father,
forever and ever.[h] 11 Yours, Yahweh, is the greatness, the power, the
glory, the victory, and the majesty; for all that is in the heavens and in
the earth is yours. Yours is the kingdom, Yahweh, and you are exalted
as head over all.[i] 12 Riches and honor come from before you, and you
are ruler over all. In your hand is power and might; it is in your hand
to make great, and to give strength to everyone. 13 Now therefore, our
God, we thank you, and praise your glorious name.
14 "But who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able to
offer so willingly as this? For all things come from you, and of your
own we have given you. 15 We are foreigners and temporary residents
in your sight, just as our ancestors all were. Our days on earth are
like a shadow that passes, and nothing remains.[j] 16 Yahweh our God,
all this store that we have prepared to build you a house for your
holy name comes from your hand, and is all your own. 17 My God,
I know that you examine the heart and take pleasure in honesty. In
the honesty of my heart I have given all these things willingly, and
now I have seen with joy your people here giving willingly to you.
18 Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, our fathers, keep
this forever in the inclinations of the thoughts of the heart of your
people, and direct their heart toward you. 19 Give my son Solomon a
wholehearted desire to keep your commands, your statutes, and your
decrees, to carry out all of them, and to build the palace for which I
have made these preparations."
20 Then David said to all the assembly, "Now bless Yahweh your God."
And all the assembly blessed Yahweh, the God of their fathers, and
bowed down and worshiped Yahweh and the king.[k] 21 On the next
day they offered sacrifices to Yahweh and offered burnt offerings to
Yahweh: a thousand bulls, a thousand rams, and a thousand lambs,
with their drink offerings, and sacrifices in abundance for all Israel. 22

They ate and drank before Yahweh on that day with great gladness. And they made Solomon the son of David king a second time, and anointed him to Yahweh to be prince, and Zadok to be priest.[l] 23 Then Solomon sat on the throne of Yahweh as king in place of David his father; and he prospered, and all Israel obeyed him. 24 All the officials and the mighty men, and also all the sons of King David, pledged their allegiance to Solomon the king.[m] 25 Yahweh magnified Solomon exceedingly in the sight of all Israel, and bestowed on him such royal majesty as had not been on any king before him in Israel.
26 Thus David the son of Jesse reigned over all Israel. 27 The time that he reigned over Israel was forty years: he reigned seven years in Hebron and thirty-three years in Jerusalem.[n] 28 He died at a good old age, full of days, riches, and honor; and Solomon his son reigned in his place. 29 Now the acts of King David, first and last, are written in the records of Samuel the seer, in the records of Nathan the prophet, and in the records of Gad the seer,[o] 30 with all his reign and his might, and the times that went over him, and over Israel, and over all the kingdoms of the lands.

Notes

- a (29:1) Hebrew birah, "citadel" or "palace," a late word used here of the temple.
- b (29:2) The identity of several of these stones is uncertain. "Antimony" (Hebrew pukh) was used as eye paint; others take it as a dark or inlay stone.
- c (29:4) Hebrew "three thousand talents of gold … seven thousand talents of refined silver": about 102 metric tons of gold and 238 metric tons of silver. Ophir, a land famous for gold, perhaps in southern Arabia or east Africa.
- d (29:5) Hebrew "to fill his hand," an idiom for consecration.
- e (29:7) Hebrew "ten thousand darics," about 84 kilograms. The daric (Hebrew 'adarkon) was a Persian gold coin of about 8.4 grams, first minted under Darius I (about 515 B.C.). Its mention here is an anachronism: the writer gives the value in the currency of his own day. Some take the word as drachmas.
- f (29:7) Hebrew "five thousand talents … ten thousand talents of silver, eighteen thousand talents of bronze, and a hundred thousand talents of iron": about 170 metric tons of gold, 340 metric tons of silver, 612 metric tons of bronze, and 3,400 metric tons of iron.
- g (29:8) Jehiel, see 23:8.
- h (29:10) Verses 10–13 are often called David's prayer. The doxology added to the Lord's Prayer in some late manuscripts of Matthew 6:13 echoes verse 11.
- i (29:11) Or "and you are exalted over all as head."

- j (29:15) Or “and there is no hope.”
- k (29:20) Bowing before the king is an act of honor, not of worship as given to God; the same Hebrew verb is used for both.
- l (29:22) “A second time” refers back to 23:1. Compare 1 Kings 1:32–40, where Solomon is anointed by Zadok and Nathan.
- m (29:24) Hebrew “gave a hand under Solomon.”
- n (29:27) Compare 2 Samuel 5:4–5 and 1 Kings 2:11, where David reigned seven years and six months in Hebron.
- o (29:29) Hebrew “in the words of Samuel the seer.” These sources may be the books of Samuel or other prophetic records.

2 Chronicles

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 Solomon the son of David strengthened himself in his kingdom, and
Yahweh his God was with him and made him exceedingly great.[a]
2 Solomon spoke to all Israel, to the commanders of thousands and of
hundreds, to the judges, and to every leader in all Israel, the heads of
the fathers' houses. 3 Solomon and the whole assembly with him went
to the high place at Gibeon, because God's tent of meeting was there,
the one that Moses the servant of Yahweh had made in the desert.[b] 4
But the ark of God David had brought up from Kiriath-jearim to the
place that David had prepared for it, for he had pitched a tent for it
in Jerusalem.[c] 5 And the bronze altar that Bezalel the son of Uri, the
son of Hur, had made was there before the tabernacle of Yahweh; and
Solomon and the assembly sought it.[d] 6 Solomon went up there to the
bronze altar before Yahweh, which was at the tent of meeting, and
offered a thousand burnt offerings on it.
7 In that night God appeared to Solomon and said to him, "Ask what
I shall give you." 8 Solomon said to God, "You have shown great
steadfast love to David my father, and have made me king in his place.
9 Now, Yahweh God, may the promise you made to my father David
come true, for you have made me king over a people as countless as
the dust of the earth. 10 Give me now wisdom and knowledge, that I
may go out and come in before this people; for who can judge this
great people of yours?" 11 God said to Solomon, "Since this was your
desire, and you did not ask for riches, wealth, or honor, or for the
death of those who hate you, or even for a long life, but asked for
wisdom and knowledge to govern my people, over whom I have made
you king, 12 Wisdom and knowledge are granted to you. On top of
that, I will give you riches, wealth, and honor, more than any king
before you has had or any king after you will have." 13 So Solomon

came from the high place at Gibeon, from before the tent of meeting, to Jerusalem; and he reigned over Israel.[e]
14 Solomon collected chariots and horsemen. He had 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horsemen, which he kept in the chariot cities and near himself in Jerusalem.[f] 15 The king made silver and gold in Jerusalem as common as stones, and he made cedars as plentiful as the sycamore-fig trees of the Shephelah.[g] 16 Solomon's horses were imported from Egypt and from Kue; the king's traders bought them from Kue at a price.[h] 17 A chariot imported from Egypt cost about 15 pounds of silver, and a horse about 3¾ pounds. They were also sold on to all the kings of the Hittites and the kings of Aram.[i]

Notes

- a (1:1) Verses 1–13 parallel 1 Kings 3:4–15. Solomon, from shalom, "peace." David, "beloved."
- b (1:3) Gibeon, "hill." Chronicles explains why Solomon worshiped at Gibeon: the tent of meeting was there (1 Chronicles 16:39; 21:29). Moses, perhaps Egyptian "born," associated in Exodus 2:10 with Hebrew "drawn out."
- c (1:4) Kiriath-jearim, "city of forests." Jerusalem, perhaps "foundation of Shalem" or "city of peace." See 1 Chronicles 13; 15.
- d (1:5) Bezalel, "in the shadow of God"; Uri, "my light" or "fiery"; Hur, perhaps "white" or "noble." The Hebrew vowels read "he had put" (sam) before the tabernacle; the Septuagint reads "was there" (sham), with the same consonants. "Sought it" may mean "sought him," that is, Yahweh.
- e (1:13) Hebrew "to the high place." The Septuagint reads "from the high place," as the context requires.
- f (1:14) Verses 14–17 parallel 1 Kings 10:26–29; compare 2 Chronicles 9:25–28.
- g (1:15) The Shephelah ("lowland") is the foothill region west of Judah.
- h (1:16) Egypt, Hebrew Mitsrayim. Kue is probably Cilicia in southeastern Asia Minor. Some interpreters read "Muzri," a land in Asia Minor, for "Egypt" in these verses.
- i (1:17) Hebrew "six hundred of silver … a hundred and fifty," probably shekels: about 6.9 kilograms and 1.7 kilograms. Hittites, descendants of Heth; Aram, perhaps "highland," here the Aramean kingdoms of Syria.

Chapter 2

1 Solomon purposed to build a house for the name of Yahweh, and a royal house for himself.[a] 2 Solomon counted out seventy thousand men to bear burdens, eighty thousand men to quarry stone in the hill country, and three thousand six hundred to oversee them.[b]

3 Solomon sent this message to Huram king of Tyre: “Deal with me
as you dealt with my father David, to whom you supplied cedar for
building the house where he would live.[c] 4 Behold, I am about to build
a house for the name of Yahweh my God, to dedicate it to him, to burn
before him incense of sweet spices, for the continual showbread, and
for burnt offerings morning and evening, on the Sabbaths, on the new
moons, and at the appointed feasts of Yahweh our God. This is for
Israel forever. 5 The house that I build is great, for our God is greater
than all gods. 6 Yet who can build a house for him, when the heavens,
even the highest heavens, cannot hold him? Who am I to build him
a house, other than a place for burning incense in his presence? 7
Now therefore send me a man skillful to work in gold, in silver, in
bronze, in iron, and in purple, crimson, and blue, who knows how
to engrave engravings, to be with the skilled men who are with me
in Judah and Jerusalem, whom David my father provided.[d] 8 Send me
also cedar trees, cypress trees, and algum trees out of Lebanon, for
I know that your servants know how to cut timber in Lebanon; and
behold, my servants will be with your servants,[e] 9 even to prepare me
timber in plenty; for the house that I am about to build shall be great
and wonderful. 10 Behold, to your servants, the woodcutters who cut
the timber, I will give about 120,000 bushels of crushed wheat, about
120,000 bushels of barley, about 120,000 gallons of wine, and about
120,000 gallons of oil.”[f]
11 Huram king of Tyre wrote a letter in reply to Solomon: “It is
because Yahweh loves his people that he has made you their king.”
12 Huram also said, “Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Israel, who made
the heavens and the earth, who has given King David a wise son,
endowed with discretion and understanding, who will build a house
for Yahweh and a royal house for himself. 13 I am now sending you
Huram-abi,[g] a skilled man with great understanding, 14 His mother
belonged to the tribe of Dan, and his father was a Tyrian. He is trained
to work in gold, silver, bronze, and iron, in stone and wood, and in
purple, blue, and crimson thread and fine linen. He can do any kind of
engraving and can carry out any design given to him, working with
your craftsmen and those of my lord, your father David.[h] 15 Now let

my lord send his servants the wheat, barley, olive oil, and wine that he promised. 16 We will cut as many trees from Lebanon as you need and float them in rafts down the sea to Joppa, and you can haul them up to Jerusalem."[i]

17 Solomon took a count of all the foreigners living in Israel, following the census his father David had taken, and the total was 153,600.[j] 18 He made seventy thousand of them bearers of burdens, eighty thousand quarriers in the hill country, and three thousand six hundred overseers to make the people work.

Notes

- a (2:1) In Hebrew, 2:1 is 1:18, and 2:2–18 are 2:1–17. Verses 1–18 parallel 1 Kings 5:1–18 (Hebrew 5:15–32).
- b (2:2) First Kings 5:16 gives three thousand three hundred overseers. Adding the chief officers (8:10 two hundred fifty; 1 Kings 9:23 five hundred fifty), both books reach a total of 3,850.
- c (2:3) Huram, a form of Hiram (as in Kings), perhaps "my brother is exalted." Tyre, "rock."
- d (2:7) Judah, associated with "praise" (Genesis 29:35).
- e (2:8) Lebanon, "white," from its snow-capped mountains. Algum is an unidentified fine wood; 1 Kings 10:11 has almug.
- f (2:10) Hebrew gives 20,000 cors each of crushed wheat and barley, and 20,000 baths each of wine and oil. A cor is about 6 bushels (220 liters), and a bath about 6 gallons (22 liters), so the totals are about 4,400,000 liters each of wheat and barley, and 440,000 liters each of wine and oil. First Kings 5:11 lists twenty thousand cors of wheat and twenty cors of beaten oil (the Septuagint of Kings has twenty thousand baths).
- g (2:13) Huram-abi, "Huram is my father," or "Huram my master craftsman"; 1 Kings 7:13 calls him Hiram.
- h (2:14) First Kings 7:14 says his mother was a widow of the tribe of Naphtali. She may have been of Danite descent living in Naphtali, or the traditions differ. Dan, "judge."
- i (2:16) Joppa, "beautiful," the port of modern Jaffa.
- j (2:17) Compare 1 Chronicles 22:2.

Chapter 3

1 Solomon began building Yahweh's house in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, the place where Yahweh had shown himself to his father David. It was at the site David had prepared, the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite.[a] 2 He began to build on the second day of the

second month (in April–May), in the fourth year of his reign.[b] 3 These
are the foundations that Solomon laid for building the house of God:
the length, by the old standard of measure, was ninety feet, and the
breadth thirty feet.[c] 4 The porch in front of the house was thirty feet
long, matching the breadth of the house, and its height was a hundred
and eighty feet; and he overlaid it inside with pure gold.[d] 5 The great
house he paneled with cypress wood, overlaid it with fine gold, and
carved palm trees and chains on it.[e] 6 He adorned the house with
precious stones for beauty; and the gold was gold of Parvaim.[f] 7 He
overlaid also the house, the beams, the thresholds, and its walls, and
its doors, with gold; and engraved cherubim on the walls.
8 He built the Most Holy Place. It was 30 feet long, matching the width
of the temple, and 30 feet wide. He covered it with about 22½ tons of
fine gold.[g] 9 The weight of the nails was about a pound and a quarter
of gold. He overlaid the upper rooms with gold.[h] 10 In the room of the
most holy place he made two cherubim of sculptured work, and they
overlaid them with gold.[i] 11 The wings of the cherubim together were
thirty feet long: one wing of the first, seven and a half feet, touched
the wall of the house, and its other wing, seven and a half feet,
touched the wing of the other cherub.[j] 12 And one wing of the other
cherub, seven and a half feet, touched the wall of the house, and its
other wing, seven and a half feet, joined the wing of the first cherub.
13 The wings of these cherubim spread out thirty feet. They stood on
their feet, facing the house.[k] 14 He made the veil of blue, purple, and
crimson yarn and fine linen, and worked cherubim on it.[l]
15 In front of the house he made two pillars about fifty-two feet high,
and the capital on the top of each was seven and a half feet.[m] 16 He
made chains in the inner sanctuary and put them on the tops of the
pillars; and he made a hundred pomegranates and put them on the
chains.[n] 17 He set up the pillars in front of the temple, one on the right
hand and the other on the left; and called the name of the one on the
right hand Jachin, and the name of the one on the left Boaz.[o]

Notes

- a (3:1) Moriah, perhaps "Yahweh provides" or "seen by Yahweh"; only here and in Genesis 22:2 ("the land of Moriah"), linking the temple site with the place of Isaac's

offering. Ornan, see 1 Chronicles 21:15; Jebusite, of Jebus ("trodden place"), the old name of Jerusalem. Verses 1–17 parallel 1 Kings 6–7.

- b (3:2) Hebrew "in the second month, on the second"; the second "on the second" is lacking in the Septuagint and may be a copying error. The second month is Ziv (1 Kings 6:1), later Iyyar, counting from the spring new year. First Kings 6:1 dates this to the 480th year after the exodus.
- c (3:3) Hebrew "the length in cubits after the first measure was sixty cubits, and the breadth twenty cubits," about 27 by 9 meters, taking a cubit as 18 inches (45 centimeters). "The first measure" was probably an older, longer cubit of about 20.5 inches (52 centimeters), which would give about 102 by 34 feet. Compare 1 Kings 6:2, which also gives a height of thirty cubits.
- d (3:4) Hebrew "twenty cubits ... a hundred and twenty," about 9 and 54 meters. Some Greek manuscripts and the Syriac read "twenty cubits" for the height; 1 Kings 6:3 gives no height for the porch.
- e (3:5) "Great house" is the main hall (the holy place).
- f (3:6) Parvaim, an unidentified source of gold, perhaps in Arabia.
- g (3:8) Hebrew "six hundred talents," about 20 metric tons, taking a talent as about 75 pounds (34 kilograms). Each dimension here is twenty cubits (about 9 meters).
- h (3:9) Hebrew "fifty shekels," about 575 grams.
- i (3:10) The meaning of the Hebrew word for "sculptured work" (tsa'atsu'im) is uncertain.
- j (3:11) Hebrew "twenty cubits ... five cubits": about 9 meters, and 2.3 meters for each wing. Compare 1 Kings 6:23–28, where the cherubim are of olive wood, ten cubits high.
- k (3:13) Or "toward the main hall."
- l (3:14) First Kings does not mention the veil at this point, but describes doors of olive wood (1 Kings 6:31–32).
- m (3:15) Hebrew "thirty-five cubits ... five cubits," about 16 meters and 2.3 meters. First Kings 7:15, 2 Kings 25:17, and Jeremiah 52:21 give eighteen cubits (about 27 feet; 8.1 meters) for each pillar; thirty-five may be their combined length, or a different measure. First Kings 7:16 gives the capitals as five cubits; 2 Kings 25:17 gives three.
- n (3:16) Hebrew "in the inner sanctuary" (baddevir); many scholars emend to "like a necklace" (karabid), since the chains were on the pillars outside.
- o (3:17) Jachin, "he establishes"; Boaz, perhaps "in him is strength."

Chapter 4

1 He made an altar of bronze, thirty feet long, thirty feet broad, and fifteen feet high.[a]

2 Then he made the Sea of cast metal, fifteen feet from brim to brim, round all about; its height was seven and a half feet, and a line of

forty-five feet measured its circumference.[b] 3 Beneath it, all around,
were figures of oxen encircling it, ten to every foot and a half,
surrounding the Sea; the oxen were in two rows, cast together with
it.[c] 4 It stood on twelve oxen, three looking toward the north, three
toward the west, three toward the south, and three toward the east;
and the Sea was set on them above, and all their hind parts were
toward the center. 5 Its thickness was about three inches, and its brim
was made like the brim of a cup, like the flower of a lily; it could
hold about eighteen thousand gallons.[d] 6 He also made ten basins for
washing, and set five on the right and five on the left. In them they
rinsed what was used for the burnt offering, but the Sea was for the
priests to wash in.
7 He made the ten lampstands of gold as prescribed for them, and set
them in the temple, five on the right and five on the left.[e] 8 He made
ten tables and placed them in the temple, five on the right and five
on the left; and he made a hundred basins of gold.[f]
9 He made the court of the priests and the great court, and doors for
the court, and overlaid their doors with bronze. 10 He set the Sea at
the right side of the house, to the southeast.
11 Huram also made the pots, the shovels, and the basins. So Huram
completed the work that he did for King Solomon on the house of
God:[g] 12 the two pillars, the two bowl-shaped tops on the pillars, and
the two networks covering the bowls on top of the pillars; 13 and the
400 pomegranates for the two networks, with two rows of pomegran-
ates on each network covering the bowl-shaped tops on the pillars. 14
He made the stands, and the basins on the stands;[h] 15 the one Sea, and
the twelve oxen under it. 16 Huram-abi made the pots, shovels, forks,
and all the related tools from polished bronze for King Solomon, for
Yahweh's house.[i] 17 In the plain of the Jordan the king cast them, in
the clay ground between Succoth and Zeredah.[j] 18 Solomon made all
these utensils in very great quantity, for the weight of the bronze was
not sought out.
19 Solomon made all the furnishings for God's house: the gold altar,
and the tables for the bread of the Presence,[k] 20 and the lampstands
with their lamps of pure gold, to burn according to the ordinance in

front of the inner sanctuary; 21 the flowers, the lamps, and the tongs, of gold, of the most perfect gold; 22 the snuffers, the basins, the dishes for incense, and the fire pans, of pure gold; and as for the entrance of the house, its inner doors to the most holy place and the doors of the house, the main hall, were of gold.[l]

Notes

- a (4:1) Hebrew "twenty cubits long, twenty cubits broad, and ten cubits high," about 9 by 9 by 4.5 meters. This altar is not described in the standard text of 1 Kings 7, though 1 Kings 8:64 and 9:25 mention it. Verses 2–5 parallel 1 Kings 7:23–26.
- b (4:2) Hebrew "ten cubits ... five cubits ... thirty cubits": about 4.5 meters across, 2.3 meters high, and 13.5 meters around. The round figure thirty for the circumference is an approximation.
- c (4:3) Hebrew "ten in a cubit." First Kings 7:24 has "gourds" (peqaʿim) instead of "oxen" (beqarim); the two Hebrew words look alike.
- d (4:5) Hebrew "a handbreadth" (about 7.5 centimeters) and "three thousand baths" (about 66,000 liters). First Kings 7:26 gives two thousand baths (about 12,000 gallons; 44,000 liters). Chronicles may include the capacity to the brim, or the figures reflect different measures.
- e (4:7) Compare Exodus 25:31–40; 1 Kings 7:49 also has ten lampstands.
- f (4:8) Or "bowls" for sprinkling.
- g (4:11) Huram, see 2:3. Verses 11–22 parallel 1 Kings 7:40–50. Hebrew "Huram" here and "Huram-abi" in verse 16; Kings has Hiram.
- h (4:14) Hebrew "he made the stands, and he made the basins"; compare 1 Kings 7:43.
- i (4:16) Hebrew "Huram his father"; see 2:13.
- j (4:17) Jordan, "descender." Succoth, "booths." Zeredah (1 Kings 7:46 Zarethan), perhaps "cooling."
- k (4:19) Hebrew "bread of the face"; see 1 Chronicles 9:32.
- l (4:22) Or "the hinges of the doors"; compare 1 Kings 7:50.

Chapter 5

1 Thus all the work that Solomon did for the house of Yahweh was finished. And Solomon brought in the holy things of David his father, the silver, the gold, and all the vessels, and put them in the treasuries of the house of God.[a]

2 Then Solomon assembled in Jerusalem the elders of Israel and all the tribal heads, the family leaders of the Israelites, to bring up Yahweh's covenant ark from the city of David, which is Zion.[b] 3 And all the men of Israel assembled before the king at the feast in the seventh

month (in September–October).[c] 4 All the elders of Israel came, and
the Levites took up the ark.[d] 5 They brought up the ark, the tent of
meeting, and all the holy vessels that were in the tent; the priests, the
Levites, brought them up.[e] 6 King Solomon and the entire community
of Israel who had assembled with him stood in front of the ark and
sacrificed so many sheep and cattle that no one could record or count
them. 7 Then the priests brought the ark of the covenant of Yahweh to
its place, into the inner sanctuary of the house, the most holy place,
beneath the wings of the cherubim. 8 For the cherubim spread out
their wings over the place of the ark, and the cherubim covered the
ark and its poles from above. 9 The poles were so long that the ends
of the poles were seen from the ark in front of the inner sanctuary,
but they could not be seen from outside; and it is there to this day.[f] 10
There was nothing in the ark except the two tablets Moses had placed
there at Horeb, where Yahweh made a covenant with the Israelites
after they came out of Egypt.[g]
11 Now when the priests came out of the holy place (for all the priests
who were present had consecrated themselves, without keeping to
their divisions,[h] 12 and the Levitical singers, all of them, Asaph,
Heman, and Jeduthun, with their sons and brothers, arrayed in fine
linen, having cymbals and stringed instruments and harps, stood
at the east end of the altar, and with them a hundred and twenty
priests blowing trumpets),[i] 13 it came to pass, when the trumpeters
and the singers were as one, to make one sound heard in praising
and thanking Yahweh, and when they raised the sound with trumpets
and cymbals and instruments of song, and praised Yahweh, "For he
is good, for his steadfast love endures forever," that the house, the
house of Yahweh, was filled with a cloud,[j] 14 so that the priests could
not stand to minister because of the cloud, for the glory of Yahweh
filled the house of God.

Notes

- a (5:1) Verses 1–14 parallel 1 Kings 7:51–8:11.
- b (5:2) Zion, perhaps "fortress" or "dry place."

- c (5:3) Hebrew “at the feast; it was the seventh month,” the month Ethanim (1 Kings 8:2), later Tishri, counting from the spring new year. The feast is Booths (compare 7:8–10).
- d (5:4) First Kings 8:3 reads “the priests took up the ark.” Chronicles names the Levites, in keeping with 1 Chronicles 15:2.
- e (5:5) The Septuagint and 1 Kings 8:4 read “the priests and the Levites.”
- f (5:9) Hebrew “it is there”; the Septuagint and 1 Kings 8:8 read “they are there.”
- g (5:10) Horeb, “dry” or “desolate,” another name for Mount Sinai.
- h (5:11) Verses 11b–13a are not in 1 Kings 8:10–11. Compare 1 Chronicles 24.
- i (5:12) Asaph, “he gathers”; Heman, “faithful”; Jeduthun, perhaps “praising.” See 1 Chronicles 25.
- j (5:13) This refrain appears also at 7:3, 6; 20:21; compare 1 Chronicles 16:34; Psalm 136.

Chapter 6

1 Then Solomon said, “Yahweh has said that he would dwell in thick
darkness.[a] 2 But I have built you a lofty house, an established place for
your dwelling forever.”[b]
3 Then the king turned his face and blessed all the assembly of Israel,
while all the assembly of Israel stood. 4 And he said, “Blessed be
Yahweh, the God of Israel, who spoke with his mouth to David my
father, and with his hands has fulfilled it, saying, 5 ‘Since the day that I
brought my people out of the land of Egypt, I chose no city among all
the tribes of Israel to build a house in, that my name might be there;
neither did I choose any man to be leader over my people Israel;[c]
6 but I have chosen Jerusalem, that my name might be there, and I
have chosen David to be over my people Israel.’ 7 Now it was in the
heart of David my father to build a house for the name of Yahweh,
the God of Israel. 8 But Yahweh said to David my father, ‘Since it was
in your heart to build a house for my name, you did well that it was
in your heart. 9 However, you will not be the one to build the temple.
Your own son, born to you, will build the temple for my name.’ 10 Now
Yahweh has established his word that he spoke; for I have risen in the
place of David my father and sit on the throne of Israel, as Yahweh
promised, and I have built the house for the name of Yahweh, the God
of Israel. 11 And there I have set the ark, in which is the covenant of
Yahweh that he made with the people of Israel.”

12 Then he stood before the altar of Yahweh in the presence of all the
assembly of Israel and spread out his hands. 13 Solomon had made
a bronze platform measuring seven and a half feet in length and
width and four and a half feet in height, and set it in the center of
the courtyard. Standing on it, he then knelt in front of the whole
assembly of Israel and spread out his hands toward heaven,[d] 14 and
said, "Yahweh, God of Israel, there is no God like you in heaven or
on earth. You keep your covenant and show faithful love to your
servants who live in your presence with all their heart. 15 who have
kept with your servant David my father what you promised him. You
spoke with your mouth, and with your hand you have fulfilled it, as
at this day. 16 So now, Yahweh, God of Israel, carry out the promise
you made to your servant David my father when you said, 'There
will always be a man from your line in my presence, seated on the
throne of Israel, provided that your sons take care to walk in my law
as you have walked before me.'[e] 17 So now, Yahweh, God of Israel, let
the word that you spoke to your servant David come true.
18 "But will God indeed dwell with man on the earth? Behold, the
heavens and the highest heavens cannot contain you, how much less
this house that I have built![f] 19 Even so, pay attention to your servant's
prayer and request, Yahweh my God, and hear the cry and the prayer
that your servant offers to you. 20 May your eyes be open day and night
toward this temple, the place you said you would put your name, and
may you hear the prayer your servant offers toward this place. 21 Hear
the requests of your servant and your people Israel when they pray
toward this place. Hear from your home in heaven, and when you
hear, pardon them.
22 "If a man sins against his neighbor, and an oath is laid on him to
make him swear, and he comes and swears before your altar in this
house,[g] 23 then hear from heaven, and act, and judge your servants,
requiting the wicked, to bring his way upon his own head, and justi-
fying the righteous, to give him according to his righteousness.
24 "If your people Israel are defeated before an enemy because they
have sinned against you, and they turn back and confess your name
and pray and plead before you in this house, 25 then hear from heaven

and forgive the sin of your people Israel, and bring them back to the land that you gave to them and to their fathers.
26 “When the heavens are shut up and there is no rain because they have sinned against you, if they pray toward this place and confess your name and turn from their sin, because you afflict them, 27 then listen in heaven and forgive the sin of your servants, your people Israel. Teach them the right path to follow, and send rain on the land you gave your people as their possession.
28 “If there is famine in the land, if there is pestilence, blight, or mildew, locust or grasshopper; if their enemies besiege them in the land of their gates; whatever plague, whatever sickness there is,[h] 29 whatever prayer, whatever plea is made by any man or by all your people Israel, who shall know every man his own plague and his own sorrow, and shall spread out his hands toward this house, 30 then listen from heaven, where you live, and forgive. Treat each one as his actions deserve, since you know his heart (you alone know the human heart), 31 that they may fear you, to walk in your ways all the days that they live on the face of the land that you gave to our fathers.
32 “Also concerning the foreigner, who is not of your people Israel, when he comes from a far country for your great name’s sake, and your mighty hand, and your outstretched arm; when they come and pray toward this house, 33 hear from heaven, your dwelling place, and act on everything the foreigner asks of you. Then all the peoples of the earth will know your name and honor you as your own people Israel do, and they will recognize that this temple I have built is called by your name.
34 “If your people go out to battle against their enemies, by whatever way you send them, and they pray to you toward this city that you have chosen and the house that I have built for your name, 35 then hear from heaven their prayer and their supplication, and maintain their cause.
36 “When they sin against you (for no one is without sin) and you become angry and hand them over to an enemy, who takes them captive to a country far or near, 37 yet if they come to their senses in the land where they are carried captive, and turn again and make

supplication to you in the land of their captivity, saying, ‘We have sinned, we have done wrong, we have acted wickedly,’ 38 and if they return to you with all their heart and soul in the land of their captivity where they were taken, and pray facing the land you gave their ancestors, the city you chose, and the temple I have built for your name, 39 then listen from heaven, where you live, to their prayer and requests, uphold their cause, and forgive your people who have sinned against you. 40 Now, my God, let, I beg you, your eyes be open, and let your ears be attentive to the prayer that is made in this place.[i] 41 “And now arise, Yahweh God, to your resting place, you and the ark of your might. Let your priests, Yahweh God, be clothed with salvation, and let your faithful ones rejoice in what is good.[j] 42 Yahweh God, do not turn away the face of your anointed one. Remember the steadfast love for David your servant.”[k]

Notes

- a (6:1) Verses 1–39 parallel 1 Kings 8:12–50.
- b (6:2) Hebrew zevul, “exalted dwelling” or “princely house.”
- c (6:5) First Kings 8:16 lacks the words “and I chose no man … but I have chosen Jerusalem, that my name might be there,” though the Septuagint of Kings has a similar clause about choosing Jerusalem.
- d (6:13) Hebrew “five cubits long, five cubits broad, and three cubits high,” about 2.3 by 2.3 by 1.4 meters. This verse is not in 1 Kings 8.
- e (6:16) First Kings 8:25 reads “to walk before me.” Chronicles stresses the law.
- f (6:18) Or “the heavens and the heavens of heavens.” Chronicles adds “with man” (compare 1 Kings 8:27).
- g (6:22) Hebrew “and he lays an oath on him to cause him to swear.”
- h (6:28) Or “in any of their cities.” Hebrew “in the land of their gates.”
- i (6:40) Verses 40–42 differ from the ending of Solomon’s prayer in 1 Kings 8:50–53. Verses 41–42 are drawn from Psalm 132:8–10, 1.
- j (6:41) Hebrew hasidim, “those who are faithful” or “godly ones.”
- k (6:42) Or “Remember the deeds of steadfast love of David your servant.” Compare Isaiah 55:3; Psalm 132:1.

Chapter 7

1 When Solomon had finished praying, fire came down from heaven and consumed the burnt offering and the sacrifices, and the glory of Yahweh filled the house.[a] 2 The priests could not enter the house of Yahweh, because the glory of Yahweh had filled the house of Yahweh.

3 When all the Israelites saw the fire come down and Yahweh's glory
fill the temple, they knelt with their faces to the ground on the
pavement, worshiped, and thanked Yahweh: "He is good; his faithful
love lasts forever."
4 Then the king and all the people offered sacrifice before Yahweh.[b] 5
King Solomon offered a sacrifice of twenty-two thousand oxen and a
hundred and twenty thousand sheep. So the king and all the people
dedicated the house of God. 6 The priests stood at their posts, and
the Levites with the instruments for the music of Yahweh that King
David had made for giving thanks to Yahweh, "for his steadfast love
endures forever," whenever David offered praise by their hand; and
the priests opposite them blew trumpets, and all Israel stood. 7 And
Solomon consecrated the middle of the court that was before the
house of Yahweh, for there he offered the burnt offerings and the
fat of the peace offerings, because the bronze altar that Solomon had
made was not able to receive the burnt offering, the grain offering,
and the fat.
8 So Solomon kept the feast at that time seven days, and all Israel with
him, a very great congregation, from the entrance of Hamath to the
Brook of Egypt.[c] 9 On the eighth day they held a closing assembly,
having observed the dedication of the altar for seven days and the
festival for seven days.[d] 10 On the twenty-third day of the seventh
month (in September–October) he sent the people away to their tents,
rejoicing and glad of heart for the good that Yahweh had done for
David and for Solomon and for Israel his people.[e]
11 Thus Solomon finished the house of Yahweh and the king's house.
And all that came into Solomon's heart to make in the house of
Yahweh and in his own house, he prosperously carried out.[f]
12 Then Yahweh appeared to Solomon at night and said, "I have heard
your prayer, and I have chosen this place for myself as a temple for
sacrifices. 13 If I close the sky so that no rain falls, or order locusts to
eat up the land, or send a plague on my people,[g] 14 and my people who
are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my
face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven
and will forgive their sin and heal their land. 15 Now my eyes will be

open and my ears attentive to the prayer of this place. 16 For now I
have chosen and sanctified this house, that my name may be there
forever; and my eyes and my heart shall be there perpetually. 17 As for
you, if you walk before me as your father David did, doing all that I
have commanded and keeping my statutes and rulings, 18 I will make
your royal throne secure, just as I promised your father David: 'You
will never lack a man to rule in Israel.'[h] 19 But if you turn away and
abandon the laws and commands I gave you, and go off to serve and
worship other gods,[i] 20 I will uproot Israel from my land that I gave
them, and I will cast out of my sight this temple that I consecrated for
my name. I will make it an object of ridicule and mockery among all
peoples. 21 And this house, which was exalted, everyone passing by
it will be appalled and will say, 'Why has Yahweh done thus to this
land and to this house?'[j] 22 Then they will say, 'Because they forsook
Yahweh, the God of their fathers, who brought them out of the land
of Egypt, and laid hold on other gods and bowed down to them and
served them; therefore he has brought all this evil upon them.'"

Notes

- a (7:1) Fire from heaven is not mentioned in 1 Kings 8:54; compare 1 Chronicles 21:26; Leviticus 9:24.
- b (7:4) Verses 4–10 parallel 1 Kings 8:62–66.
- c (7:8) Lebo-hamath, "entrance of Hamath," the northern limit of the land; Hamath, "fortress." The Brook of Egypt is probably the Wadi el-Arish, the southern limit.
- d (7:9) The feast is Booths, which began on the fifteenth of the seventh month (Leviticus 23:34–36); the dedication of the altar was held the week before.
- e (7:10) The seventh month is Ethanim (1 Kings 8:2), later Tishri, counting from the spring new year. First Kings 8:66 says "on the eighth day he sent the people away"; Chronicles counts the final assembly before their departure the next day.
- f (7:11) Verses 11–22 parallel 1 Kings 9:1–9.
- g (7:13) Verses 13–15 are not in 1 Kings 9.
- h (7:18) First Kings 9:5 reads "a man on the throne of Israel." Compare Micah 5:2.
- i (7:19) "You" here is plural, addressing Solomon and the people.
- j (7:21) Hebrew "which was high." Some propose reading "will become a heap of ruins" (compare 1 Kings 9:8).

Chapter 8

1 At the end of twenty years, in which Solomon had built the house of
Yahweh and his own house,[a] 2 Solomon built the cities that Huram had
given to Solomon, and caused the children of Israel to dwell there.[b]
3 Solomon went to Hamath-zobah and took it by force.[c] 4 He built
Tadmor in the wilderness and all the store cities that he built in
Hamath.[d] 5 He also built Beth-horon the upper and Beth-horon the
lower, fortified cities, with walls, gates, and bars,[e] 6 Baalath, all the
storage cities Solomon owned, all the cities for his chariots and
horsemen, and everything else Solomon wanted to build in Jerusalem,
in Lebanon, and throughout his territory.[f]
7 All the people who were left of the Hittites, the Amorites, the
Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites, who were not of Israel,[g] 8
Their descendants who remained in the land after them, whom the
Israelites had not wiped out, were drafted by Solomon for forced
labor, and so they are to this day. 9 Yet of the Israelites Solomon made
no slaves for his work. They were his soldiers, his chief officers, and
the commanders of his chariots and horsemen. 10 These were the chief
officers of King Solomon, two hundred and fifty, who ruled over the
people.[h]
11 Solomon moved Pharaoh's daughter from the city of David to the
palace he had built for her, saying, "My wife must not live in David's
house, since David was king of Israel and the places where the ark of
Yahweh has come are holy."[i]
12 Then Solomon offered burnt offerings to Yahweh on the altar of
Yahweh that he had built before the porch, 13 even as the duty of every
day required, offering according to the commandment of Moses on
the Sabbaths, on the new moons, and the appointed feasts three times
a year: the Feast of Unleavened Bread, the Feast of Weeks, and the
Feast of Booths.[j] 14 Following the instructions of his father David, he
assigned the priests' divisions to their service, the Levites to lead
praise and to assist the priests according to each day's duties, and the
gatekeepers by their divisions at every gate, as David the man of God
had ordered. 15 And they did not turn aside from the king's command
to the priests and Levites concerning any matter, or concerning the

treasuries. [16] So all the work of Solomon was carried out from the day
the foundation of the house of Yahweh was laid until it was finished.
The house of Yahweh was complete.[k]
[17] Then Solomon went to Ezion-geber and to Eloth on the seashore in
the land of Edom.[l] [18] Huram sent him ships, and servants who knew
the sea, through his own men. They sailed with Solomon's servants
to Ophir and brought back about 17 tons of gold to King Solomon.[m]

Notes

- a (8:1) Verses 1–18 parallel 1 Kings 9:10–28.
- b (8:2) First Kings 9:10–14 says Solomon gave Hiram twenty cities in Galilee, which displeased him. Chronicles may describe their return, or follows a different tradition.
- c (8:3) Hamath-zobah, Hamath in the region of Zobah ("station"). No campaign of Solomon is recorded in Kings.
- d (8:4) Tadmor, "palm," later Palmyra in the Syrian desert. First Kings 9:18 has Tamar (Ketiv), a town in the southern wilderness of Judah, with Qere Tadmor.
- e (8:5) Beth-horon, "house of the hollow."
- f (8:6) Baalath, "lady," a town of Dan (Joshua 19:44).
- g (8:7) Hittites, see 1:17; Amorites, "westerners" or "mountain dwellers"; Perizzites, "villagers"; Hivites, perhaps "tent villagers"; Jebusites, see 3:1.
- h (8:10) First Kings 9:23 gives five hundred fifty. See 2:2 note.
- i (8:11) Pharaoh, Egyptian "great house," the title of Egypt's king. The reason given here is not in 1 Kings 9:24.
- j (8:13) Compare Exodus 23:14–17; Deuteronomy 16:16. Booths, Hebrew Sukkot.
- k (8:16) Hebrew "until its finishing"; the Septuagint reads "until Solomon finished the house of the Lord."
- l (8:17) Ezion-geber, perhaps "backbone of a strong man"; Eloth (Elath), "terebinths"; Edom, "red."
- m (8:18) Hebrew "four hundred and fifty talents," about 15.3 metric tons. First Kings 9:28 gives four hundred twenty talents. Kings says Solomon built a fleet and Hiram sent sailors (9:26–27). Ophir, see 1 Chronicles 29:4.

Chapter 9

[1] When the queen of Sheba heard about Solomon's fame, she came to
Jerusalem to test him with hard questions. She arrived with a very
large caravan, with camels carrying spices, a great amount of gold,
and precious stones. She came to Solomon and talked with him about
everything on her mind.[a] [2] Solomon told her all her questions, and
there was nothing hid from Solomon which he did not tell her. [3] When

the queen of Sheba saw the wisdom of Solomon, the house that he had
built, 4 the food of his table, the seating of his officials, the standing of
his ministers and their apparel, his cupbearers and their apparel, and
his ascent by which he went up to the house of Yahweh, there was no
more breath in her.[b] 5 She told the king, "The report I heard in my own
country about your achievements and your wisdom was true. 6 I did
not trust their words until I came and saw it with my own eyes. Not
even half of your great wisdom was told to me. You are greater than
the report I heard. 7 Blessed are your men, and blessed are these your
servants who stand continually before you and hear your wisdom![c] 8
Praise Yahweh your God, who delighted in you and placed you on his
throne to rule for Yahweh your God. Because your God loves Israel
and wants them to last forever, he has made you their king, to carry
out justice and righteousness."[d] 9 She gave the king about four and a
half tons of gold, and spices in great abundance, and precious stones;
neither was there ever such spices as those the queen of Sheba gave to
King Solomon.[e] 10 Moreover the servants of Huram and the servants
of Solomon, who brought gold from Ophir, brought algum wood and
precious stones. 11 And the king made from the algum wood steps for
the house of Yahweh and for the king's house, and lyres and harps for
the singers; none like them had been seen before in the land of Judah.[f]
12 King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba everything she wanted and
asked for, in addition to what she had brought him. Then she and her
servants left and returned to her own country.[g]
13 The weight of gold that came to Solomon in one year was about
twenty-five tons of gold,[h] 14 not counting what the traders and mer-
chants brought. All the kings of Arabia and the governors of the land
also brought gold and silver to Solomon.[i] 15 King Solomon made two
hundred large shields of beaten gold; about fifteen pounds of beaten
gold went into each large shield.[j] 16 And he made three hundred small
shields of beaten gold; about seven and a half pounds of gold went
into each shield. The king put them in the House of the Forest of
Lebanon.[k] 17 The king also made a great throne of ivory and overlaid it
with pure gold. 18 There were six steps to the throne, with a footstool
of gold, which were fastened to the throne, and stays on either side

by the place of the seat, and two lions standing beside the stays;[l] 19 and twelve lions stood there on the one side and on the other upon the six steps; there was not the like made in any kingdom. 20 All King Solomon's drinking vessels were of gold, and all the vessels of the House of the Forest of Lebanon were of pure gold; silver was not counted as anything in the days of Solomon. 21 For the king's ships went to Tarshish with the servants of Huram; once every three years the ships of Tarshish came, bringing gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks.[m]

22 Thus King Solomon excelled all the kings of the earth in riches and in wisdom. 23 And all the kings of the earth sought the presence of Solomon to hear his wisdom, which God had put in his heart. 24 They brought every man his tribute: vessels of silver and vessels of gold, clothing, weapons, spices, horses, and mules, so much year by year.[n] 25 Solomon had 4,000 stalls for horses and chariots and 12,000 horsemen, whom he kept in the chariot cities and near himself in Jerusalem.[o] 26 He ruled over all the kings from the River to the land of the Philistines and to the border of Egypt.[p] 27 The king made silver as common in Jerusalem as stones, and he made cedars as plentiful as the sycamore-fig trees of the Shephelah. 28 And horses were brought for Solomon from Egypt and from all lands.

29 Now the rest of the acts of Solomon, first and last, are they not written in the words of Nathan the prophet, and in the prophecy of Ahijah the Shilonite, and in the visions of Iddo the seer concerning Jeroboam the son of Nebat?[q] 30 Solomon reigned in Jerusalem over all Israel forty years. 31 And Solomon slept with his fathers and was buried in the city of David his father; and Rehoboam his son reigned in his place.[r]

Notes

- a (9:1) Verses 1–12 parallel 1 Kings 10:1–13. Sheba, probably in southwest Arabia (modern Yemen).
- b (9:4) Or "his burnt offerings that he offered at the house of Yahweh"; 1 Kings 10:5 has "his burnt offering." The Hebrew here, 'aliyyato, means "his ascent" or "his upper chamber."
- c (9:7) The Septuagint of Kings reads "your wives" for "your men" in 1 Kings 10:8; the Hebrew words are similar.

- d (9:8) First Kings 10:9 reads “on the throne of Israel”; Chronicles speaks of the throne as God’s own.
- e (9:9) Hebrew “a hundred and twenty talents,” about 4.1 metric tons.
- f (9:11) Or “paths” or “stairs”; the Hebrew (mesillot) is uncertain. First Kings 10:12 has “supports” or “railings” (mis‘ad).
- g (9:12) The Hebrew text is difficult; it may mean “besides what she had brought in exchange.”
- h (9:13) Verses 13–28 parallel 1 Kings 10:14–29. Hebrew “six hundred and sixty-six talents,” about 22.6 metric tons.
- i (9:14) Arabia, “steppe” or “desert.”
- j (9:15) Hebrew “six hundred of beaten gold,” probably shekels: about 6.9 kilograms.
- k (9:16) Hebrew “three hundred of gold,” probably shekels: about 3.45 kilograms. First Kings 10:17 has “three minas of gold,” about 1.7 kilograms if a mina is fifty shekels. On the House of the Forest of Lebanon see 1 Kings 7:2–5.
- l (9:18) First Kings 10:19 describes a rounded top to the throne instead of the footstool. The Hebrew words are not alike.
- m (9:21) First Kings 10:22 reads “the king had a fleet of ships of Tarshish,” probably large seagoing ships; Chronicles has the ships go to Tarshish (perhaps Tartessus in Spain). “Peacocks” may be baboons; the meaning of the Hebrew (tukkiyyim) is uncertain.
- n (9:24) Or “myrrh” for “weapons”; the Hebrew (nesheq) is uncertain.
- o (9:25) First Kings 4:26 (Hebrew 5:6) gives forty thousand stalls; many think four thousand original. Compare 1:14; 1 Kings 10:26.
- p (9:26) The River is the Euphrates. Philistines, perhaps “wanderers” or “immigrants.”
- q (9:29) Compare 1 Kings 11:41, which cites “the book of the acts of Solomon.” Nathan, “he has given”; Ahijah, “brother of Yahweh”; Shilonite, of Shiloh; Iddo, perhaps “timely” or “adorned”; Jeroboam, perhaps “the people contends” or “may the people increase”; Nebat, “he has looked.” Chronicles omits the account of Solomon’s wives and the revolts of 1 Kings 11.
- r (9:31) Rehoboam, “the people is enlarged.”

Chapter 10

1 Rehoboam went to Shechem, for all Israel had come to Shechem to
make him king.[a] 2 And when Jeroboam the son of Nebat heard of it (for
he was in Egypt, where he had fled from King Solomon), Jeroboam
returned from Egypt.[b] 3 They sent and called him, and Jeroboam and
all Israel came and spoke to Rehoboam, saying, 4 “Your father made
our burden heavy. Now ease the harsh labor and the heavy burden

your father placed on us, and we will serve you." [5] He said to them, "Return to me after three days." So the people went away.
[6] Then King Rehoboam consulted with the old men who had stood before Solomon his father while he was alive, saying, "How do you advise me to answer this people?" [7] They told him, "If you are kind to these people, satisfy them, and give them a favorable answer, they will be your servants forever." [8] But he rejected the advice the elders had given him and consulted the young men who had grown up with him and were serving him. [9] He said to them, "What counsel do you give, that we may return answer to this people, who have spoken to me, saying, 'Make the yoke that your father put on us lighter'?" [10] The young men who had grown up with him spoke to him, saying, "Thus you shall tell the people who spoke to you, saying, 'Your father made our yoke heavy, but make it lighter for us'; thus you shall say to them, 'My little finger is thicker than my father's loins.[c] [11] And now, whereas my father laid on you a heavy yoke, I will add to your yoke. My father disciplined you with whips, but I will discipline you with scorpions.'"[d]
[12] So Jeroboam and all the people came to Rehoboam on the third day, as the king had said, "Return to me on the third day." [13] And the king answered them harshly; King Rehoboam forsook the counsel of the old men, [14] and spoke to them according to the counsel of the young men, saying, "My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to it. My father disciplined you with whips, but I will discipline you with scorpions." [15] So the king did not listen to the people, for it was brought about by God, that Yahweh might establish his word, which he spoke by Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam the son of Nebat.[e]
[16] When all Israel saw that the king did not listen to them, the people answered the king, saying, "What portion have we in David? We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse. To your tents, each man, O Israel! Now see to your own house, David." So all Israel went to their tents.[f] [17] But as for the people of Israel who lived in the cities of Judah, Rehoboam reigned over them. [18] King Rehoboam sent out Hadoram, who was in charge of forced labor, but the Israelites stoned him to

death. King Rehoboam hurried to get into his chariot and escape to Jerusalem.[g] 19 So Israel rebelled against the house of David to this day.

Notes

- a (10:1) Verses 1–19 parallel 1 Kings 12:1–19. Rehoboam, see 9:31. Shechem, "shoulder" or "ridge."
- b (10:2) First Kings 12:2 reads "Jeroboam stayed in Egypt"; the Hebrew words for "returned" and "stayed" are similar (wayyashov, wayyeshev). Chronicles assumes the account of Jeroboam in 1 Kings 11:26–40, which it does not include.
- c (10:10) Hebrew "than my father's loins," that is, his waist.
- d (10:11) "Scorpions" may be whips tipped with barbs or metal points.
- e (10:15) Ahijah, see 9:29; compare 1 Kings 11:29–39.
- f (10:16) Jesse, perhaps "Yahweh exists" or "gift."
- g (10:18) Hadoram, perhaps "Hadad is exalted"; 1 Kings 12:18 has Adoram, and 1 Kings 4:6 Adoniram.

Chapter 11

1 When Rehoboam reached Jerusalem, he gathered the families of Judah and Benjamin, 180,000 chosen soldiers, to fight against Israel and bring the kingdom back to Rehoboam.[a] 2 But the word of Yahweh came to Shemaiah the man of God, saying,[b] 3 "Say to Rehoboam the son of Solomon, king of Judah, and to all Israel in Judah and Benjamin, 4 'Thus says Yahweh: You shall not go up or fight against your brothers. Return every man to his house, for this thing is from me.'" So they listened to the words of Yahweh and turned back from going against Jeroboam.

5 Rehoboam dwelt in Jerusalem, and built cities for defense in Judah.[c] 6 He built Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa,[d] 7 Beth-zur, Soco, Adullam,[e] 8 Gath, Mareshah, Ziph,[f] 9 Adoraim, Lachish, Azekah,[g] 10 Zorah, Aijalon, and Hebron, which are fortified cities in Judah and in Benjamin.[h] 11 He fortified the strongholds and put captains in them, with stores of food, oil, and wine. 12 And in every city he put shields and spears and made them very strong. So he held Judah and Benjamin.

13 The priests and Levites throughout Israel took their stand with him from all their regions. 14 For the Levites left their pasture lands and their possession and came to Judah and Jerusalem; for Jeroboam and his sons cast them off, that they should not execute the priest's office to Yahweh; 15 He appointed his own priests for the high places, for the

goat idols, and for the calves he had made.[i] 16 And after them, out of
all the tribes of Israel, those who had set their hearts to seek Yahweh,
the God of Israel, came to Jerusalem to sacrifice to Yahweh, the God
of their fathers. 17 They strengthened the kingdom of Judah and made
Rehoboam the son of Solomon secure for three years, for they walked
for three years in the way of David and Solomon.
18 Rehoboam took as wife Mahalath the daughter of Jerimoth the son
of David, and of Abihail the daughter of Eliab the son of Jesse.[j] 19 She
bore him sons: Jeush, Shemariah, and Zaham.[k] 20 After her he took
Maacah the daughter of Absalom, and she bore him Abijah, Attai,
Ziza, and Shelomith.[l] 21 Rehoboam loved Maacah the daughter of
Absalom above all his wives and his concubines (for he took eighteen
wives and sixty concubines, and fathered twenty-eight sons and sixty
daughters). 22 And Rehoboam appointed Abijah the son of Maacah
as chief, as leader among his brothers, for he intended to make him
king. 23 He dealt wisely, and dispersed of all his sons throughout all
the lands of Judah and Benjamin, to every fortified city; and he gave
them food in abundance, and he sought for them many wives.[m]

Notes

- a (11:1) Verses 1–4 parallel 1 Kings 12:21–24. Benjamin, "son of the right hand" or "son of the south."
- b (11:2) Shemaiah, "Yahweh has heard."
- c (11:5) Verses 5–23 have no parallel in Kings.
- d (11:6) Bethlehem, "house of bread"; Etam, perhaps "place of birds of prey"; Tekoa, perhaps "trumpet blast."
- e (11:7) Beth-zur, "house of rock"; Soco, perhaps "thorny" or "branches"; Adullam, perhaps "refuge."
- f (11:8) Gath, "winepress"; Mareshah, "summit"; Ziph, perhaps "refining" or "flowing."
- g (11:9) Adoraim, perhaps "two mounds"; Lachish, meaning uncertain; Azekah, perhaps "hoed ground."
- h (11:10) Zorah, perhaps "hornet"; Aijalon, "place of deer"; Hebron, "association" or "alliance."
- i (11:15) Hebrew seʿirim, "goats" or "hairy ones," goat-shaped demons; compare Leviticus 17:7. On the calves see 1 Kings 12:28–33.
- j (11:18) The Ketiv reads "son of Jerimoth"; the Qere, "daughter of Jerimoth." Mahalath, perhaps "sickness" or "lyre" (compare the Psalm titles); Jerimoth, "heights";

Abihail, “my father is strength”; Eliab, “my God is father.” Jerimoth is not among David’s sons in 1 Chronicles 3.

- k (11:19) Jeush, “he comes to help”; Shemariah, “Yahweh keeps”; Zaham, perhaps “loathing.”
- l (11:20) Hebrew “daughter” may mean “granddaughter”; 13:2 calls Abijah’s mother Micaiah the daughter of Uriel. Maacah, perhaps “oppression” or “dull”; Absalom, “father of peace” (1 Kings 15:2 Abishalom); Abijah, “Yahweh is my father” (1 Kings 15:1 Abijam); Attai, perhaps “timely”; Ziza, “abundance”; Shelomith, “peaceful.”
- m (11:23) Hebrew “and he asked for a multitude of wives.”

Chapter 12

1 When the kingdom of Rehoboam was established and he was strong,
he forsook the law of Yahweh, and all Israel with him.[a] 2 In the fifth
year of King Rehoboam, because they had been unfaithful to Yahweh,
Shishak king of Egypt came up against Jerusalem[b] 3 with 1,200 chari-
ots and 60,000 horsemen. The troops who came with him from Egypt
were beyond counting: Libyans, Sukkiim, and Cushites.[c] 4 He took the
fortified cities which belonged to Judah, and came to Jerusalem.
5 Then Shemaiah the prophet came to Rehoboam and to the princes
of Judah who had gathered at Jerusalem because of Shishak, and said
to them, “Thus says Yahweh: You forsook me, so I also have forsaken
you into the hand of Shishak.” 6 Then the princes of Israel and the
king humbled themselves and said, “Yahweh is righteous.” 7 When
Yahweh saw that they humbled themselves, the word of Yahweh
came to Shemaiah, saying, “They have humbled themselves; I will
not destroy them, but I will grant them deliverance in a little while,
and my wrath shall not be poured out on Jerusalem by the hand of
Shishak.[d] 8 Nevertheless they shall be his servants, so that they may
know my service and the service of the kingdoms of the lands.”
9 Shishak king of Egypt marched against Jerusalem. He carried off
the treasures of Yahweh’s house and of the royal palace; he took
everything. He also took the gold shields that Solomon had made,[e] 10
King Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace them and entrusted
them to the officers of the guard on duty at the palace entrance.[f] 11
And whenever the king went into the house of Yahweh, the runners
came and carried them and brought them back to the guardroom of
the runners. 12 And when he humbled himself, the wrath of Yahweh

turned from him, so as not to destroy him completely. Moreover, conditions were good in Judah.[g]

13 King Rehoboam established himself firmly in Jerusalem and continued as king. Rehoboam was 41 years old when he became king, and he ruled 17 years in Jerusalem, the city Yahweh had chosen from all the tribes of Israel as the place to put his name. His mother's name was Naamah, an Ammonite.[h] 14 He did that which was evil, because he did not set his heart to seek Yahweh.

15 Now the acts of Rehoboam, first and last, are they not written in the words of Shemaiah the prophet and of Iddo the seer, in the matter of genealogies? There were wars between Rehoboam and Jeroboam continually.[i] 16 And Rehoboam slept with his fathers and was buried in the city of David, and Abijah his son reigned in his place.

Notes

- a (12:1) Verses 1–16 expand 1 Kings 14:21–31.
- b (12:2) Shishak (Egyptian Sheshonq I) founded Egypt's Twenty-second Dynasty; his own inscription at Karnak lists towns he took in Judah and Israel, about 925 B.C.
- c (12:3) Libyans, Hebrew Lubim; Sukkiim, perhaps Libyan troops (Egyptian Tjukten) or "tent dwellers"; Cushites, people of Cush, the upper Nile region (Nubia).
- d (12:7) Or "some deliverance." Hebrew "as a little, deliverance."
- e (12:9) First Kings 14:26 adds "all the shields of gold."
- f (12:10) Hebrew "the runners," the royal guard.
- g (12:12) Or "and in Judah there were good things." Compare 19:3.
- h (12:13) Naamah, "pleasant"; Ammonite, of Ammon ("people" or "kinsman"). Verses 13–14 parallel 1 Kings 14:21–22.
- i (12:15) Hebrew "to be enrolled by genealogy"; the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 13

1 In the eighteenth year of King Jeroboam, Abijah began to reign over Judah.[a] 2 He ruled three years in Jerusalem. His mother was Micaiah, the daughter of Uriel from Gibeah. Abijah and Jeroboam were at war.[b] 3 Abijah joined battle with an army of valiant men of war, four hundred thousand chosen men; and Jeroboam set the battle in array against him with eight hundred thousand chosen men, mighty men of valor.[c]

4 Then Abijah stood up on Mount Zemaraim, which is in the hill country of Ephraim, and said, "Hear me, Jeroboam and all Israel![d]

5 Ought you not to know that Yahweh, the God of Israel, gave the
kingdom over Israel to David forever, to him and to his sons, by a
covenant of salt?[e] 6 Yet Jeroboam son of Nebat, who served Solomon
son of David, stood up and rebelled against his master. 7 and worth-
less men gathered about him, scoundrels, and they prevailed against
Rehoboam the son of Solomon, when Rehoboam was young and
fainthearted and could not stand against them.[f] 8 And now you plan
to resist the kingdom of Yahweh, which is in the hands of David's
descendants. You are a huge crowd, and you have with you the
golden calves that Jeroboam made as your gods. 9 Didn't you drive
out the priests of Yahweh, the descendants of Aaron, and the Levites,
and appoint your own priests like the peoples of other countries?
Anyone who comes to be ordained with a young bull and seven rams
becomes a priest of what are not gods.[g] 10 But as for us, Yahweh is
our God, and we have not forsaken him. We have priests ministering
to Yahweh who are sons of Aaron, and Levites at their work. 11 They
offer to Yahweh every morning and every evening burnt offerings and
incense of sweet spices, and set out the showbread on the pure table,
and tend the golden lampstand with its lamps to burn every evening;
for we keep the charge of Yahweh our God, but you have forsaken
him. 12 See, God is with us as our leader, and his priests are here with
their trumpets to sound the battle call against you. People of Israel,
do not fight against Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, because you
will not win."
13 But Jeroboam caused an ambush to come about behind them; so
they were before Judah, and the ambush was behind them. 14 And
when Judah turned, behold, the battle was before and behind them.
They cried to Yahweh, and the priests blew the trumpets. 15 Then
the men of Judah gave a shout; and as the men of Judah shouted,
God struck Jeroboam and all Israel before Abijah and Judah. 16 The
children of Israel fled before Judah, and God delivered them into
their hand. 17 Abijah and his people struck them with a great blow,
and five hundred thousand chosen men of Israel fell slain.[h] 18 So the
Israelites were defeated at that time, and the people of Judah won,
because they depended on Yahweh, the God of their ancestors. 19 And

Abijah pursued Jeroboam and took cities from him: Bethel with its villages, Jeshanah with its villages, and Ephron with its villages.[i] 20 Jeroboam did not regain strength again in the days of Abijah; and Yahweh struck him down, and he died.[j]

21 But Abijah grew strong. He took fourteen wives and fathered twenty-two sons and sixteen daughters. 22 The rest of the acts of Abijah, his ways and his sayings, are written in the study of the prophet Iddo.[k]

Notes

- a (13:1) Verses 1–2 parallel 1 Kings 15:1–2, 6–7. Kings calls him Abijam and judges him harshly (15:3); Chronicles records his speech and victory.
- b (13:2) Micaiah, "who is like Yahweh?"; Uriel, "God is my light"; Gibeah, "hill." The Septuagint and 1 Kings 15:2 read Maacah, as in 11:20.
- c (13:3) These numbers, and those of verse 17, are very large; Hebrew 'eleph, "thousand," may in such lists denote a military unit.
- d (13:4) Zemaraim, perhaps "two wool-heaps"; Ephraim, "doubly fruitful."
- e (13:5) A covenant of salt is a lasting, unbreakable covenant; compare Numbers 18:19.
- f (13:7) Hebrew "young and tender of heart."
- g (13:9) "To fill his hand" is the idiom for ordaining a priest.
- h (13:17) See verse 3 note.
- i (13:19) Bethel, "house of God"; Jeshanah, "old." The Ketiv reads Ephron; the Qere, Ephrain. Ephron, "fawn-like."
- j (13:20) First Kings 14:20 says Jeroboam reigned twenty-two years; he outlived Abijah (1 Kings 15:9). "He died" here may anticipate his later death.
- k (13:22) Hebrew midrash, "study," "commentary," or "record."

Chapter 14

1 So Abijah slept with his fathers, and they buried him in the city of David; and Asa his son reigned in his place. In his days the land was quiet for ten years.[a] 2 Asa did what was good and right in the eyes of Yahweh his God.[b] 3 He removed the foreign altars and high places, smashed the sacred pillars, and cut down the Asherah poles.[c] 4 and commanded Judah to seek Yahweh, the God of their fathers, and to do the law and the commandment. 5 He also removed the high places and incense altars from every city of Judah, and the kingdom enjoyed peace under him.[d] 6 He built fortified cities in Judah while the land was at peace. No one fought against him in those years, since Yahweh

gave him rest. 7 And he said to Judah, “Let us build these cities and surround them with walls and towers, gates and bars. The land is still before us, because we have sought Yahweh our God; we have sought him, and he has given us rest on every side.” So they built and prospered.
8 Asa had an army that bore bucklers and spears: out of Judah three hundred thousand, and out of Benjamin, that bore shields and drew bows, two hundred and eighty thousand; all these were mighty men of valor. 9 Zerah the Cushite came out against them with an army of a thousand thousands and three hundred chariots, and he came as far as Mareshah.[e] 10 Then Asa went out to meet him, and they set the battle in array in the Valley of Zephathah at Mareshah.[f] 11 And Asa cried to Yahweh his God and said, “Yahweh, there is none besides you to help, between the mighty and him who has no strength. Help us, Yahweh our God, for we rely on you, and in your name we have come against this multitude. Yahweh, you are our God; let not man prevail against you.” 12 So Yahweh struck the Cushites before Asa and before Judah, and the Cushites fled. 13 Asa and the people who were with him pursued them as far as Gerar, and so many of the Cushites fell that none remained alive, for they were broken before Yahweh and before his army. The men of Judah carried away very much plunder.[g] 14 And they struck all the cities around Gerar, for the dread of Yahweh was on them. They plundered all the cities, for there was much plunder in them. 15 They also attacked the camps of the herdsmen and carried off many sheep and camels. Then they went back to Jerusalem.

Notes

- a (14:1) In Hebrew, 14:1 is 13:23, and 14:2–15 are 14:1–14. Asa, perhaps “healer.” Verses 1–3 parallel 1 Kings 15:8–11.
- b (14:2) Hebrew “in the eyes of.”
- c (14:3) Asherim, wooden poles or trees honoring the goddess Asherah.
- d (14:5) Hebrew hammanim, perhaps incense stands; older versions, “sun images.” First Kings 15:14 and 2 Chronicles 15:17 say the high places were not removed; Chronicles may distinguish idolatrous shrines from high places used for Yahweh, or Judah from Israel.
- e (14:9) Zerah, “rising” or “dawning”; Cushite, see 12:3. Hebrew “a thousand thousand(s)”; see 13:3 note.

- f (14:10) Zephathah, “watchtower.” The Septuagint reads “in the valley north of Mareshah,” reflecting a different reading of the same consonants.
- g (14:13) Gerar, “lodging place.” Or “so that they could not recover.”

Chapter 15

1 The Spirit of God came upon Azariah the son of Oded,[a] 2 and he went
out to meet Asa and said to him, “Hear me, Asa, and all Judah and
Benjamin: Yahweh is with you while you are with him. If you seek
him, he will be found by you; but if you forsake him, he will forsake
you. 3 For a long time Israel was without the true God, and without
a teaching priest, and without law.[b] 4 But when in their distress they
turned to Yahweh, the God of Israel, and sought him, he was found
by them. 5 In those times there was no peace to him who went out nor
to him who came in, but great troubles were on all the inhabitants of
the lands. 6 Nation was crushed by nation, and city by city, for God
troubled them with every kind of distress. 7 But you, be strong, and
do not let your hands be slack, for there is a reward for your work.”
8 When Asa heard these words, the prophecy of Oded the prophet, he
took courage and put away the abominations out of all the land of
Judah and Benjamin, and out of the cities which he had taken from the
hill country of Ephraim; and he renewed the altar of Yahweh that was
before the porch of Yahweh.[c] 9 He gathered all Judah and Benjamin,
and those who sojourned with them out of Ephraim, Manasseh, and
Simeon; for they fell to him out of Israel in abundance when they
saw that Yahweh his God was with him.[d] 10 They were gathered at
Jerusalem in the third month (in May–June) of the fifteenth year
of the reign of Asa.[e] 11 They sacrificed to Yahweh on that day, from
the plunder that they had brought, seven hundred oxen and seven
thousand sheep. 12 And they entered into a covenant to seek Yahweh,
the God of their fathers, with all their heart and with all their soul, 13
and that whoever would not seek Yahweh, the God of Israel, should
be put to death, whether small or great, whether man or woman. 14
They swore an oath to Yahweh with a loud voice, with shouting, with
trumpets, and with horns. 15 And all Judah rejoiced over the oath, for
they had sworn with all their heart and had sought him with their

whole desire, and he was found by them; and Yahweh gave them rest all around.
16 King Asa even removed his mother Maacah from her position as queen mother, because she had made a disgusting image of Asherah. Asa chopped down her image, ground it up, and burned it in the Kidron Valley.[f] 17 But the high places were not taken away out of Israel; yet the heart of Asa was perfect all his days.[g] 18 He brought into the house of God the things that his father had dedicated and that he himself had dedicated, silver, gold, and vessels. 19 There was no more war to the thirty-fifth year of Asa's reign.[h]

Notes

- a (15:1) Azariah, "Yahweh has helped"; Oded, perhaps "restorer."
- b (15:3) This may describe the time of the judges, or be a general warning; compare Hosea 3:4.
- c (15:8) Hebrew "and the prophecy, Oded the prophet"; the words "Azariah the son of" may have dropped out (compare verse 1). The Septuagint also reads "Oded" (Brenton "Adad").
- d (15:9) Manasseh, "causing to forget"; Simeon, "hearing."
- e (15:10) The third month, later Sivan, counting from the spring new year; the Feast of Weeks fell in this month. The covenant oath (Hebrew shevuʿah) may play on Shavuʿot, "Weeks."
- f (15:16) Verses 16–18 parallel 1 Kings 15:13–15. Maacah, see 11:20; she was Asa's grandmother (1 Kings 15:2, 10, "mother" in the wider sense). Kidron, perhaps "dark" or "turbid."
- g (15:17) Compare 14:5 note.
- h (15:19) First Kings 16:8 places the death of Baasha (16:1) in Asa's twenty-sixth year. The thirty-fifth and thirty-sixth years (here and 16:1) may be counted from the division of the kingdom, or the numbers may have been miscopied.

Chapter 16

1 In the thirty-sixth year of the reign of Asa, Baasha king of Israel went up against Judah and built Ramah, so that he might not allow anyone to go out or come in to Asa king of Judah.[a] 2 Then Asa brought out silver and gold from the treasuries of the house of Yahweh and of the king's house, and sent to Ben-hadad king of Aram, who lived in Damascus, saying,[b] 3 "There is a treaty between me and you, as there was between my father and your father. Behold, I am sending you silver and gold. Go, break your treaty with Baasha king of Israel, that

he may withdraw from me." 4 Ben-hadad listened to King Asa, and
sent the commanders of his armies against the cities of Israel; and
they struck Ijon, Dan, Abel-maim, and all the store cities of Naphtali.[c]
5 When Baasha heard of it, he stopped building Ramah and let his
work cease. 6 Then Asa the king took all Judah, and they carried away
the stones of Ramah and the timber of it, with which Baasha had built;
and he built Geba and Mizpah with them.[d]
7 At that time Hanani the seer came to Asa king of Judah and said
to him, "Because you relied on the king of Aram, and did not rely
on Yahweh your God, the army of the king of Aram has escaped out
of your hand.[e] 8 Were not the Cushites and the Libyans a huge army
with chariots and very many horsemen? Yet because you relied on
Yahweh, he gave them into your hand. 9 For the eyes of Yahweh run to
and fro throughout the whole earth, to show himself strong on behalf
of those whose heart is wholly true to him. You have done foolishly
in this, for from now on you will have wars." 10 Then Asa was angry
with the seer and put him in the stocks, for he was in a rage with
him because of this. And Asa oppressed some of the people at the
same time.[f]
11 The acts of Asa, first and last, behold, they are written in the book
of the kings of Judah and Israel.[g] 12 In the thirty-ninth year of his reign
Asa was diseased in his feet, and his disease became very severe; yet
even in his disease he did not seek Yahweh, but the physicians.[h] 13 Asa
died in the forty-first year of his reign and was laid to rest with his
ancestors. 14 They buried him in his own tomb, which he had hewn
out for himself in the city of David, and laid him in the bed which
was filled with sweet odors and various kinds of spices prepared by
the perfumers' art; and they made a very great burning for him.[i]

Notes

- a (16:1) Verses 1–6 parallel 1 Kings 15:16–22. Baasha, meaning uncertain; Ramah, "height." See 15:19 note.
- b (16:2) Ben-hadad, "son of Hadad," the storm god; Aram, see 1:17; Damascus, meaning uncertain.
- c (16:4) Ijon, perhaps "ruin"; Abel-maim, "meadow of waters" (1 Kings 15:20 Abel-beth-maacah); Naphtali, "my wrestling."
- d (16:6) Geba, "hill"; Mizpah, "watchtower."

- e (16:7) Hanani, “gracious.” Verses 7–10 are not in Kings.
- f (16:10) Hebrew “the house of the stocks.”
- g (16:11) Compare 1 Kings 15:23–24.
- h (16:12) Or “but sought the physicians”; perhaps a play on Asa’s name if it means “healer.”
- i (16:14) The fire was a burning of spices in his honor, not a cremation; compare 21:19; Jeremiah 34:5.

Chapter 17

1 Jehoshaphat his son reigned in his place and strengthened himself
against Israel.[a] 2 He placed forces in all the fortified cities of Judah,
and set garrisons in the land of Judah and in the cities of Ephraim that
Asa his father had taken. 3 Yahweh was with Jehoshaphat, because he
walked in the earlier ways of his father David, and did not seek the
Baals,[b] 4 but sought the God of his father and walked in his command-
ments, and not according to the deeds of Israel. 5 Therefore Yahweh
established the kingdom in his hand. All Judah brought tribute to
Jehoshaphat, and he had riches and honor in abundance. 6 His heart
was lifted up in the ways of Yahweh; and moreover he took away the
high places and the Asherim out of Judah.[c]
7 In the third year of his reign he sent his princes, Ben-hail, Obadiah,
Zechariah, Nethanel, and Micaiah, to teach in the cities of Judah;[d] 8
and with them the Levites Shemaiah, Nethaniah, Zebadiah, Asahel,
Shemiramoth, Jehonathan, Adonijah, and Tobijah, and Tob-adonijah,
as well as the priests Elishama and Jehoram.[e] 9 They taught in Judah,
having the book of the law of Yahweh with them. They went about
through all the cities of Judah and taught among the people.
10 Fear of Yahweh came over all the kingdoms of the lands around
Judah, so they did not go to war against Jehoshaphat. 11 Some of the
Philistines brought Jehoshaphat gifts and silver as tribute. Arabs also
brought him flocks: 7,700 rams and 7,700 male goats. 12 Jehoshaphat
grew great exceedingly; and he built castles and store cities in Judah.
13 and he had much work in the cities of Judah; and he had men of
war, mighty men of valor, in Jerusalem. 14 This is the muster of them
by their fathers’ houses: Of Judah, the captains of thousands: Adnah
the captain, and with him three hundred thousand mighty men of

valor;[f] 15 and next to him Jehohanan the captain, and with him two
hundred and eighty thousand;[g] 16 and next to him Amasiah the son
of Zichri, who offered himself willingly to Yahweh, and with him
two hundred thousand mighty men of valor.[h] 17 Of Benjamin: Eliada,
a mighty man of valor, and with him two hundred thousand armed
with bow and shield;[i] 18 and next to him Jehozabad, and with him a
hundred and eighty thousand ready for war.[j] 19 These were those who
served the king, besides those whom the king had put in the fortified
cities throughout all Judah.

Notes

- a (17:1) Jehoshaphat, "Yahweh has judged." Compare 1 Kings 15:24; 22:41–50.
- b (17:3) The Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts lack "David," giving "the earlier ways of his father," that is, Asa. Baals, local forms of the god Baal ("lord, owner").
- c (17:6) Hebrew "his heart was high," here in a good sense, "he took courage." Contrast 20:33.
- d (17:7) Ben-hail, "son of strength" (or read "his princes, men of valor"); Obadiah, "servant of Yahweh"; Zechariah, "Yahweh remembers"; Nethanel, "God has given"; Micaiah, see 13:2.
- e (17:8) Shemaiah, see 11:2; Nethaniah, "Yahweh has given"; Zebadiah, "Yahweh has bestowed"; Asahel, "God has made"; Shemiramoth, perhaps "name of heights"; Jehonathan, "Yahweh has given"; Adonijah, "my lord is Yahweh"; Tobijah, "Yahweh is good"; Tob-adonijah, "good is my lord Yahweh"; Elishama, "God has heard"; Jehoram, "Yahweh is exalted."
- f (17:14) Adnah, "pleasure." The total of verses 14–18 (1,160,000) is very large; see 13:3 note.
- g (17:15) Jehohanan, "Yahweh is gracious."
- h (17:16) Amasiah, "Yahweh carries"; Zichri, "remembered."
- i (17:17) Eliada, "God knows."
- j (17:18) Jehozabad, "Yahweh has bestowed."

Chapter 18

1 Now Jehoshaphat had riches and honor in abundance, and he made
a marriage alliance with Ahab.[a] 2 After some years he went down to
Ahab in Samaria. Ahab slaughtered sheep and oxen in abundance for
him and for the people who were with him, and urged him to go up
against Ramoth-gilead.[b] 3 Ahab king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat king
of Judah, "Will you go with me to Ramoth-gilead?" He answered him,

"I am as you are, and my people as your people; we will be with you in the war."
4 And Jehoshaphat said to the king of Israel, "Inquire first, I pray you, for the word of Yahweh." 5 Then the king of Israel gathered the prophets together, four hundred men, and said to them, "Shall we go to Ramoth-gilead to battle, or shall I forbear?" They said, "Go up, for God will give it into the hand of the king." 6 But Jehoshaphat said, "Is there not here another prophet of Yahweh, that we may inquire of him?" 7 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, "There is yet one man by whom we may inquire of Yahweh, but I hate him, for he never prophesies good concerning me, but always evil. He is Micaiah the son of Imla." And Jehoshaphat said, "Let not the king say so."[c] 8 Then the king of Israel called an officer and said, "Bring quickly Micaiah the son of Imla."[d] 9 Now the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat king of Judah were sitting each on his throne, clothed in their robes; they sat at the threshing floor at the entrance of the gate of Samaria, and all the prophets were prophesying before them.[e] 10 Zedekiah the son of Chenaanah made himself horns of iron and said, "Thus says Yahweh: 'With these you shall push the Arameans until they are consumed.'"[f] 11 All the prophets prophesied so, saying, "Go up to Ramoth-gilead and prosper, for Yahweh will give it into the hand of the king."
12 The messenger who went to call Micaiah spoke to him, saying, "Behold, the words of the prophets declare good to the king with one mouth. Let your word, I pray you, be like one of theirs, and speak good." 13 And Micaiah said, "As Yahweh lives, what my God says, that will I speak." 14 When he had come to the king, the king said to him, "Micaiah, shall we go to Ramoth-gilead to battle, or shall I forbear?" And he said, "Go up and prosper; they shall be given into your hand." 15 The king said to him, "How many times shall I adjure you that you speak to me nothing but the truth in the name of Yahweh?" 16 And he said, "I saw all Israel scattered on the mountains, as sheep that have no shepherd. And Yahweh said, 'These have no master; let them return each to his house in peace.'" 17 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, "Did I not tell you that he would not prophesy good concerning me, but evil?" 18 Micaiah continued, "Therefore listen to

the word of Yahweh: I saw Yahweh sitting on his throne, with all the host of heaven standing on his right and on his left. 19 Yahweh asked, 'Who will lure Ahab king of Israel into attacking Ramoth-gilead and dying there?' One suggested one thing, and another suggested something else. 20 Then a spirit stepped forward, stood in front of Yahweh, and said, 'I will lure him.' 'How?' Yahweh asked.[g] 21 'I will go out and become a lying spirit in the mouths of all his prophets,' he said. Yahweh said, 'You will lure him, and you will succeed. Go and do it.' 22 Now therefore, behold, Yahweh has put a lying spirit in the mouth of these your prophets, and Yahweh has spoken evil concerning you."
23 Then Zedekiah the son of Chenaanah came near and struck Micaiah on the cheek and said, "Which way did the Spirit of Yahweh go from me to speak to you?" 24 And Micaiah said, "Behold, you shall see on that day, when you go into an inner chamber to hide yourself." 25 And the king of Israel said, "Take Micaiah, and carry him back to Amon the governor of the city and to Joash the king's son,[h] 26 and say, 'Thus says the king: Put this fellow in the prison, and feed him with bread of affliction and with water of affliction, until I return in peace.'"[i] 27 Micaiah said, "If you ever come back safely, Yahweh has not spoken through me." He added, "Listen, all you peoples!"[j]
28 So the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat the king of Judah went up to Ramoth-gilead. 29 The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, "I will disguise myself and go into the battle, but you put on your robes." So the king of Israel disguised himself, and they went into the battle. 30 Now the king of Aram had ordered his chariot commanders, "Do not fight with anyone, small or great, except the king of Israel." 31 When the captains of the chariots saw Jehoshaphat, they said, "It is the king of Israel." So they turned about to fight against him. But Jehoshaphat cried out, and Yahweh helped him; God drew them away from him.[k] 32 When the captains of the chariots saw that it was not the king of Israel, they turned back from pursuing him. 33 But a certain man drew his bow at random and struck the king of Israel between the joints of the armor. So he said to the driver of the chariot, "Turn your hand and carry me out of the army, for I am badly wounded."[l] 34 The battle grew fierce that day, and the king of Israel held himself up in his chariot

facing the Arameans until evening; and about the time of the going down of the sun he died.[m]

Notes

- a (18:1) Ahab, "father's brother." The marriage was of Jehoram son of Jehoshaphat to Athaliah daughter of Ahab (21:6; 22:2). Chapter 18 closely parallels 1 Kings 22:1–35.
- b (18:2) Samaria, "watch post"; Ramoth-gilead, "heights of Gilead."
- c (18:7) Micaiah, "who is like Yahweh?"; Imla, "he fills."
- d (18:8) The Ketiv spells the name Micaihu, a longer form.
- e (18:9) Or "in an open place." Zedekiah (next verse) and the prophets performed before the two kings.
- f (18:10) Zedekiah, "Yahweh is righteousness"; Chenaanah, perhaps "merchant" or "Canaanitess."
- g (18:20) Hebrew "With what?"
- h (18:25) Amon, "faithful" or "master workman"; Joash, perhaps "Yahweh has given."
- i (18:26) That is, meager prison rations.
- j (18:27) The same words open the book of the prophet Micah (Micah 1:2). They are absent from the Septuagint of 1 Kings 22:28 but present in Hebrew Kings and here.
- k (18:31) "And Yahweh helped him; God drew them away" is not in 1 Kings 22:32.
- l (18:33) The Ketiv reads "your hands," the Qere "your hand." Hebrew "out of the camp."
- m (18:34) First Kings 22:35–38 adds that the blood ran into the chariot and that dogs licked it up at Samaria.

Chapter 19

1 And Jehoshaphat the king of Judah returned to his house in
Jerusalem in peace. 2 But Jehu the son of Hanani the seer went out to
meet him and said to King Jehoshaphat, "Should you help the wicked
and love those who hate Yahweh? Because of this, wrath has gone
out against you from Yahweh.[a] 3 Nevertheless, there are good things
found in you, in that you have removed the Asheroth out of the land,
and have set your heart to seek God."[b]
4 Jehoshaphat dwelt at Jerusalem. And he went out again among the
people, from Beersheba to the hill country of Ephraim, and brought
them back to Yahweh, the God of their fathers.[c] 5 He appointed judges
in the land in all the fortified cities of Judah, city by city,[d] 6 He told the
judges, "Think about what you are doing, because you are judging

on behalf of Yahweh, not people, and he is with you whenever you
give a verdict. 7 So let the fear of Yahweh be on you. Act carefully, for
Yahweh our God does not tolerate injustice, partiality, or bribes."
8 Moreover in Jerusalem Jehoshaphat appointed some of the Levites
and priests and heads of fathers' houses of Israel, to give judgment for
Yahweh and to decide disputes. And they returned to Jerusalem.[e] 9 He
commanded them, "This is how you must act: in the fear of Yahweh,
faithfully, and wholeheartedly. 10 Whenever any controversy comes
to you from your brothers who dwell in their cities, between blood
and blood, between law and commandment, statutes and ordinances,
you shall warn them, that they not be guilty toward Yahweh, and so
wrath come upon you and upon your brothers. This do, and you shall
not be guilty.[f] 11 And behold, Amariah the chief priest is over you in
all matters of Yahweh; and Zebadiah the son of Ishmael, the ruler
of the house of Judah, in all the king's matters; and the Levites will
be officers before you. Deal courageously, and may Yahweh be with
the good."[g]

Notes

- a (19:2) Jehu, "Yahweh is he"; Hanani, see 16:7.
- b (19:3) Asheroth, plural of Asherah; see 14:3 note.
- c (19:4) Beersheba, "well of seven" or "well of the oath." Jehoshaphat's name, "Yahweh has judged," suits his judicial reform (verses 5–11).
- d (19:5) Compare Deuteronomy 16:18–20; 17:8–13.
- e (19:8) The Septuagint reads "to judge the inhabitants of Jerusalem," a different vocalization of "they returned" (Hebrew vayyashuvu, read as yoshvei, "inhabitants of").
- f (19:10) "Between blood and blood," that is, cases of homicide and bloodshed.
- g (19:11) Amariah, "Yahweh has said"; Zebadiah, see 17:8; Ishmael, "God hears."

Chapter 20

1 After this the children of Moab and the children of Ammon, and
with them some of the Meunites, came against Jehoshaphat to battle.[a]
2 Some people came and told Jehoshaphat, "A huge army is coming
against you from beyond the sea, from Aram. They are already at
Hazazon-tamar" (that is, En-gedi).[b] 3 Jehoshaphat was frightened and
resolved to seek Yahweh, and he announced a fast throughout Judah.

4 And Judah gathered together to seek help from Yahweh; from all the
cities of Judah they came to seek Yahweh.
5 And Jehoshaphat stood in the assembly of Judah and Jerusalem, in
the house of Yahweh, before the new court, 6 and said, "O Yahweh,
the God of our fathers, are not you God in heaven? And are not you
ruler over all the kingdoms of the nations? Power and might are in
your hand, so that none is able to withstand you. 7 Did you not, our
God, drive out the inhabitants of this land before your people Israel,
and give it forever to the seed of Abraham your friend?[c] 8 And they
have dwelt in it and have built you a sanctuary in it for your name,
saying, 9 'If evil comes upon us, the sword, judgment, or pestilence, or
famine, we will stand before this house and before you, for your name
is in this house, and cry to you in our affliction, and you will hear
and save.'[d] 10 Now here are the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir.
When Israel came from Egypt you did not allow them to invade these
nations, so Israel turned away from them and did not destroy them.[e]
11 behold, they reward us by coming to cast us out of your possession,
which you have given us to inherit. 12 O our God, will you not judge
them? For we have no might against this great company that comes
against us; neither know we what to do, but our eyes are upon you."
13 And all Judah stood before Yahweh, with their little ones, their
wives, and their children. 14 Then the Spirit of Yahweh came upon
Jahaziel the son of Zechariah, the son of Benaiah, the son of Jeiel,
the son of Mattaniah, a Levite of the sons of Asaph, in the midst of
the assembly.[f] 15 and he said, "Hearken, all Judah, and you inhabitants
of Jerusalem, and you King Jehoshaphat: Yahweh says this to you,
'Do not be afraid, and do not be dismayed by reason of this great
multitude, for the battle is not yours but God's. 16 Go down against
them tomorrow. They will come up by the pass of Ziz, and you will
find them at the end of the ravine, east of the desert of Jeruel.[g] 17 You
shall not need to fight in this battle. Set yourselves, stand still, and
see the salvation of Yahweh with you, O Judah and Jerusalem.' Fear
not, nor be dismayed; tomorrow go out against them, for Yahweh is
with you."[h]

18 Then Jehoshaphat bowed his head with his face to the ground, and
all Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem fell down before Yahweh,
worshiping Yahweh. 19 And the Levites, of the sons of the Kohathites
and of the sons of the Korahites, stood up to praise Yahweh, the God
of Israel, with a very loud voice.[i]
20 Early in the morning they set out for the desert of Tekoa. As they
went, Jehoshaphat stood and said, "Listen to me, people of Judah
and residents of Jerusalem: Trust in Yahweh your God and you will
stand firm; trust in his prophets and you will succeed."[j] 21 When he
had taken counsel with the people, he appointed those who should
sing to Yahweh and praise the splendor of holiness, as they went out
before the army, and say, "Give thanks to Yahweh, for his steadfast
love endures forever."[k] 22 And when they began to sing and to praise,
Yahweh set ambushes against the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount
Seir, who had come against Judah, and they were struck down. 23 For
the children of Ammon and Moab stood up against the inhabitants
of Mount Seir, utterly to slay and destroy them; and when they had
made an end of the inhabitants of Seir, everyone helped to destroy
another. 24 When Judah came to the watchtower of the wilderness,
they looked upon the multitude; and behold, they were dead bodies
fallen to the earth, and there were none that escaped. 25 When
Jehoshaphat and his people came to take the plunder of them, they
found among them in abundance goods and corpses and precious
things, which they stripped off for themselves, more than they could
carry away; and they were three days in taking the plunder, it was
so much.[l]
26 On the fourth day they assembled in the Valley of Beracah, for
there they blessed Yahweh. Therefore the name of that place has been
called the Valley of Beracah to this day.[m] 27 Then they returned, every
man of Judah and Jerusalem, with Jehoshaphat at their head, return-
ing to Jerusalem with joy, for Yahweh had made them rejoice over
their enemies. 28 They came to Jerusalem with psalteries and harps
and trumpets, to the house of Yahweh. 29 And the fear of God came on
all the kingdoms of the countries when they heard that Yahweh had

fought against the enemies of Israel. 30 So the realm of Jehoshaphat was quiet, for his God gave him rest all around.
31 Thus Jehoshaphat reigned over Judah. He was thirty-five years old when he began to reign, and he reigned twenty-five years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Azubah the daughter of Shilhi.[n] 32 He walked in the way of Asa his father and departed not from it, doing that which was right in the eyes of Yahweh. 33 However, the high places were not taken away; neither as yet had the people set their hearts on the God of their fathers.[o] 34 Now the rest of the acts of Jehoshaphat, first and last, behold, they are written in the words of Jehu the son of Hanani, which are recorded in the book of the kings of Israel.
35 After this Jehoshaphat king of Judah joined himself with Ahaziah king of Israel, who did very wickedly.[p] 36 And he joined himself with him to make ships to go to Tarshish; and they made the ships in Ezion-geber.[q] 37 Then Eliezer the son of Dodavahu of Mareshah prophesied against Jehoshaphat, saying, "Because you have joined yourself with Ahaziah, Yahweh has broken up your works." And the ships were wrecked and were not able to go to Tarshish.[r]

Notes

- a (20:1) Hebrew "some of the Ammonites," which repeats the Ammonites just named; the Septuagint reads "Minaeans," that is, Meunites (compare 26:7). Moab, see 1 Chronicles 1:46 note; Ammon, "people."
- b (20:2) Hebrew and Septuagint "from Aram"; many scholars read "from Edom" (the Hebrew letters d and r are easily confused), since the invaders came from the south around the Dead Sea ("the sea"). Hazazon-tamar, perhaps "gravel bed of the palm"; En-gedi, "spring of the young goat."
- c (20:7) Compare Isaiah 41:8; James 2:23.
- d (20:9) Compare Solomon's prayer, 6:28–30.
- e (20:10) Seir, "hairy" or "shaggy," the hill country of Edom. Compare Deuteronomy 2:4–19.
- f (20:14) Jahaziel, "God sees"; Benaiah, "Yahweh has built"; Jeiel, meaning uncertain; Mattaniah, "gift of Yahweh"; Asaph, "gatherer."
- g (20:16) Ziz, perhaps "blossom"; Jeruel, perhaps "founded by God." Hebrew "before," that is, facing east.
- h (20:17) Compare Exodus 14:13.
- i (20:19) Kohathites, from Kohath ("assembly"?); Korahites, from Korah ("baldness").

- j (20:20) Tekoa, perhaps “trumpet blast.” “Believe … be established” plays on two forms of the Hebrew verb ’aman; compare Isaiah 7:9.
- k (20:21) Or “in holy attire.” “Steadfast love,” Hebrew hesed.
- l (20:25) Hebrew “corpses” (pegarim); some scholars read “garments” (begadim), which differs by one letter. The Septuagint reads “cattle and furniture and spoils.”
- m (20:26) Beracah, “blessing.”
- n (20:31) Verses 31–34 parallel 1 Kings 22:41–45. Azubah, “forsaken”; Shilhi, perhaps “sent.”
- o (20:33) First Kings 22:43 says the people still sacrificed and burned incense on the high places. Compare 17:6, where Jehoshaphat removed high places; the two statements may concern different kinds of shrines or stages of the reign.
- p (20:35) Ahaziah, “Yahweh has grasped.” Or “and he (Jehoshaphat) did very wickedly in doing so.”
- q (20:36) Tarshish, a distant western port; compare 9:21 note. First Kings 22:48–49 says Jehoshaphat built “ships of Tarshish” (a type of large seagoing ship) to go to Ophir for gold, and that he refused Ahaziah’s offer to partner in the venture. Chronicles may have read “ships of Tarshish” as ships going to Tarshish; Ezion-geber lay on the Red Sea, not the Mediterranean. Ezion-geber, perhaps “backbone of a man.”
- r (20:37) Eliezer, “God is help”; Dodavahu, “beloved of Yahweh.” This prophecy is not in Kings.

Chapter 21

1 Jehoshaphat slept with his fathers and was buried with his fathers in
the city of David, and Jehoram his son reigned in his place.[a] 2 He had
brothers, the sons of Jehoshaphat: Azariah, Jehiel, Zechariah, Azari-
ahu, Michael, and Shephatiah; all these were the sons of Jehoshaphat
king of Israel.[b] 3 Their father gave them many gifts of silver, gold,
and valuables, along with fortified cities in Judah, but he gave the
kingdom to Jehoram because he was the firstborn. 4 When Jehoram
had risen up over the kingdom of his father and had made himself
strong, he killed all his brothers with the sword, and also some of the
princes of Israel.
5 Jehoram was thirty-two years old when he began to reign, and he
reigned eight years in Jerusalem.[c] 6 He walked in the way of the kings
of Israel, as did the house of Ahab, for he had the daughter of Ahab
as wife; and he did that which was evil in the sight of Yahweh. 7
Yet Yahweh would not destroy the house of David, because of the
covenant that he had made with David, and since he had promised to

give a lamp to him and to his sons forever.[d] 8 In his days Edom revolted
from under the hand of Judah and made a king over themselves. 9
Then Jehoram passed over with his captains and all his chariots with
him; and he rose up by night and struck the Edomites who had
surrounded him and the captains of the chariots.[e] 10 So Edom revolted
from under the hand of Judah to this day. At that same time Libnah
also revolted from under his hand, because he had forsaken Yahweh,
the God of his fathers.[f] 11 Moreover, he made high places in the hill
country of Judah, and caused the inhabitants of Jerusalem to commit
fornication, and led Judah astray.[g]
12 A letter came to Jehoram from the prophet Elijah: "This is what
Yahweh, the God of your ancestor David, says: 'You have not walked
as your father Jehoshaphat did, or as Asa king of Judah did,[h] 13 but
have walked in the way of the kings of Israel, and have made Judah
and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to commit fornication, as the house
of Ahab did, and also have killed your brothers of your father's house,
who were better than you, 14 behold, Yahweh will strike with a great
blow your people, your sons, your wives, and all your goods, 15 and
you shall have great sickness by disease of your bowels, until your
bowels fall out by reason of the sickness, day by day.'"
16 And Yahweh stirred up against Jehoram the spirit of the Philistines
and of the Arabians who are near the Cushites;[i] 17 They invaded Judah,
broke into it, and carried off everything of value found in the king's
palace, along with his sons and his wives. The only son left to him
was Jehoahaz, his youngest.[j] 18 And after all this Yahweh struck him
in his bowels with a disease for which there was no healing. 19 In the
course of time, at the end of two years, his bowels came out because
of his disease, and he died in severe pain. His people made no burning
for him, like the burning for his fathers.[k] 20 He was thirty-two years
old when he began to reign, and he reigned in Jerusalem eight years;
and he departed without being desired. They buried him in the city
of David, but not in the sepulchres of the kings.[l]

Notes

- a (21:1) Jehoram, "Yahweh is exalted"; also Joram. Verses 1 and 5–10 parallel 2 Kings 8:16–22.

- b (21:2) Azariah, "Yahweh has helped" (twice, in slightly different Hebrew forms); Jehiel, "God lives"; Michael, "who is like God?"; Shephatiah, "Yahweh has judged." "King of Israel" here means king of Judah, the true Israel in Chronicles' view; the Septuagint reads "king of Judah."
- c (21:5) Jehoram may have reigned for some years alongside his father (compare 2 Kings 1:17; 3:1; 8:16).
- d (21:7) Hebrew "a lamp," a living descendant on the throne; compare 1 Kings 11:36.
- e (21:9) Second Kings 8:21 says Joram went over to Zair, and that his army fled home; the outcome was an escape, not a victory.
- f (21:10) Libnah, "whiteness," a town in the Shephelah near Philistia.
- g (21:11) The Septuagint reads "in the cities of Judah." "Commit fornication," that is, be unfaithful to Yahweh by idolatry.
- h (21:12) Elijah, "my God is Yahweh." Elijah is not otherwise linked with Jehoram of Judah, and 2 Kings 2–3 seems to place Elijah's departure before Jehoram's reign (Elisha is active under Jehoshaphat, 2 Kings 3:11). The letter may have been written beforehand, or Elijah may have lived into the early years of Jehoram's coregency; the matter is debated.
- i (21:16) Cush, see 12:3.
- j (21:17) Jehoahaz, "Yahweh has grasped," the same elements as Ahaziah (22:1) in reverse order.
- k (21:19) Hebrew "in severe diseases." On the burning, see 16:14 note.
- l (21:20) Not in the tombs of the kings: this detail is not in Kings (compare 2 Kings 8:24).

Chapter 22

1 The people of Jerusalem made Ahaziah, Jehoram's youngest son,
king in his place, because the raiding party that came with the Arabs
to the camp had killed all the older sons. So Ahaziah son of Jehoram
became king of Judah.[a] 2 Ahaziah was forty-two years old when he
began to reign, and he reigned one year in Jerusalem. His mother's
name was Athaliah, the granddaughter of Omri.[b] 3 He also walked in
the ways of the house of Ahab, for his mother was his counselor in
doing wickedly. 4 He did that which was evil in the sight of Yahweh, as
did the house of Ahab; for they were his counselors after the death of
his father, to his destruction. 5 He also followed their advice and went
with Joram son of Ahab king of Israel to fight Hazael king of Aram at
Ramoth-gilead. The Arameans wounded Joram.[c] 6 And he returned to
be healed in Jezreel of the wounds that they had given him at Ramah,
when he fought against Hazael king of Aram. And Azariah the son

of Jehoram king of Judah went down to see Jehoram the son of Ahab in Jezreel, because he was sick.[d]
7 Now the destruction of Ahaziah was of God, in that he went to Joram; for when he had come, he went out with Jehoram against Jehu the son of Nimshi, whom Yahweh had anointed to cut off the house of Ahab.[e] 8 And when Jehu was executing judgment on the house of Ahab, he found the princes of Judah and the sons of Ahaziah's brothers who served Ahaziah, and he killed them.[f] 9 He sought Ahaziah, and they caught him (now he was hiding in Samaria), and they brought him to Jehu and slew him; and they buried him, for they said, "He is the son of Jehoshaphat, who sought Yahweh with all his heart." And the house of Ahaziah had no power to hold the kingdom.[g]
10 Now when Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the royal seed of the house of Judah.[h] 11 But Jehoshabeath, the king's daughter, took Ahaziah's son Joash and secretly carried him off from among the princes who were being killed. She put him and his nurse in a bedroom. In this way Jehoshabeath, daughter of King Jehoram and wife of Jehoiada the priest (she was Ahaziah's sister), hid him from Athaliah, so that Athaliah could not kill him.[i] 12 He was with them hidden in the house of God six years, and Athaliah reigned over the land.

Notes

- a (22:1) Ahaziah, "Yahweh has grasped"; also called Jehoahaz (21:17). Verses 1–6 parallel 2 Kings 8:24–29.
- b (22:2) Hebrew "forty-two," which is impossible if his father died at forty (21:20). Second Kings 8:26 reads "twenty-two," and the Septuagint here reads "twenty." Athaliah, "Yahweh is exalted"; Omri, meaning uncertain. Hebrew "daughter," in the wider sense; she was Ahab's daughter (21:6).
- c (22:5) Hazael, "God sees."
- d (22:6) Ramah, short for Ramoth-gilead. Hebrew "Azariah"; the Septuagint and 2 Kings 8:29 read "Ahaziah," which is surely meant (compare verses 1, 7). Jezreel, "God sows."
- e (22:7) Jehu, see 19:2; Nimshi, perhaps "weasel." Compare 2 Kings 9–10.
- f (22:8) Second Kings 10:12–14 calls them "the brothers of Ahaziah" and gives their number as forty-two.
- g (22:9) Second Kings 9:27–28 says that Ahaziah, wounded near Ibleam, fled to Megiddo and died there, and that his servants carried him to Jerusalem for burial.

Chronicles summarizes differently; the accounts may reflect different sources or stages of his flight.

- h (22:10) Verses 10–12 parallel 2 Kings 11:1–3.
- i (22:11) Jehoshabeath, "Yahweh is an oath" (2 Kings 11:2 Jehosheba); Joash, see 18:25; Jehoiada, "Yahweh knows." That she was the wife of Jehoiada is stated only in Chronicles.

Chapter 23

1 In the seventh year Jehoiada strengthened himself and took the captains of hundreds into covenant with him: Azariah the son of Jeroham, Ishmael the son of Jehohanan, Azariah the son of Obed, Maaseiah the son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat the son of Zichri.[a] 2 They traveled through Judah and gathered the Levites from every town of Judah, together with the heads of the families of Israel, and they came to Jerusalem. 3 And all the assembly made a covenant with the king in the house of God. And Jehoiada said to them, "Behold, the king's son shall reign, as Yahweh spoke concerning the sons of David. 4 This is the thing that you shall do: a third part of you that come in on the Sabbath, of the priests and of the Levites, shall be porters of the thresholds,[b] 5 and a third part shall be at the king's house, and a third part at the Gate of the Foundation; and all the people shall be in the courts of the house of Yahweh.[c] 6 But let none come into the house of Yahweh, save the priests and they that minister of the Levites; they shall come in, for they are holy; but all the people shall keep the charge of Yahweh.[d] 7 The Levites are to surround the king, each with his weapons in hand. Anyone who enters the temple must be put to death. Stay close to the king wherever he goes."

8 So the Levites and all Judah did according to all that Jehoiada the priest commanded. They each took his men, those who were to come in on the Sabbath, with those who were to go out on the Sabbath, for Jehoiada the priest did not dismiss the divisions. 9 And Jehoiada the priest delivered to the captains of hundreds the spears and the large and small shields that had been King David's, which were in the house of God. 10 And he set all the people, every man with his weapon in his hand, from the right side of the house to the left side of the house, along the altar and the house, around the king. 11 Then

they brought out the king's son and put the crown on him and gave him the testimony, and made him king; and Jehoiada and his sons anointed him, and they said, "Long live the king!"[e]
12 When Athaliah heard the noise of the people running and praising the king, she came to the people into the house of Yahweh. 13 She looked and saw the king standing by his pillar at the entrance, with the officers and trumpeters beside him. All the people of the land were rejoicing and blowing trumpets, and singers with musical instruments led the praise. Athaliah tore her clothes and cried out, "Treason! Treason!"[f] 14 Jehoiada the priest brought out the captains of hundreds who were set over the army, and said to them, "Bring her out between the ranks; and whoever follows her, let him be slain with the sword." For the priest said, "Slay her not in the house of Yahweh." 15 So they made way for her; and she went to the entrance of the Horse Gate to the king's house, and they slew her there.[g]
16 And Jehoiada made a covenant between himself and all the people and the king, that they should be Yahweh's people. 17 All the people went to the house of Baal and broke it down, and broke his altars and his images in pieces, and slew Mattan the priest of Baal before the altars.[h] 18 Jehoiada appointed the offices of the house of Yahweh under the hand of the priests the Levites, whom David had distributed in the house of Yahweh, to offer the burnt offerings of Yahweh, as it is written in the law of Moses, with rejoicing and with singing, as David had ordained. 19 He stationed the gatekeepers at the gates of the house of Yahweh, so that no one who was unclean in anything should enter. 20 He took with him the commanders of hundreds, the nobles, the rulers of the people, and all the people of the land, and they escorted the king down from Yahweh's house through the Upper Gate to the palace, where they seated the king on the royal throne. 21 So all the people of the land rejoiced, and the city was quiet; and they had slain Athaliah with the sword.

Notes

- a (23:1) Chapter 23 parallels 2 Kings 11:4–20; Chronicles names the five captains and gives a larger role to the Levites. Azariah, see 15:1; Jeroham, "he is shown compassion"; Ishmael, see 19:11; Jehohanan, see 17:15; Obed, "servant"; Maaseiah,

"work of Yahweh"; Adaiah, "Yahweh has adorned"; Elishaphat, "God has judged"; Zichri, see 17:16.

- b (23:4) Hebrew "of the thresholds," that is, the temple entrances.
- c (23:5) Second Kings 11:6 reads "the Gate of Sur."
- d (23:6) That is, stay in the outer courts as Yahweh requires.
- e (23:11) "The testimony," perhaps a copy of the covenant law (compare Deuteronomy 17:18), or a royal document.
- f (23:13) Hebrew "Conspiracy! Conspiracy!"
- g (23:15) Hebrew "made two sides for her," that is, made way for her or seized her.
- h (23:17) Mattan, "gift."

Chapter 24

1 Joash was seven years old when he began to reign, and he
reigned forty years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Zibiah of
Beersheba.[a] 2 And Joash did what was right in the eyes of Yahweh all
the days of Jehoiada the priest. 3 Jehoiada took for him two wives, and
he fathered sons and daughters.
4 After this Joash decided to restore the house of Yahweh.[b] 5 He called
together the priests and Levites and said, "Go out to the towns of
Judah and every year collect money from all Israel for the repair of
your God's house. Hurry!" But the Levites did not hurry. 6 The king
called for Jehoiada the chief, and said to him, "Why have you not
required of the Levites to bring in out of Judah and out of Jerusalem
the tax of Moses the servant of Yahweh, and of the assembly of Israel,
for the tent of the testimony?"[c] 7 For the sons of Athaliah, that wicked
woman, had broken into the house of God, and had also used all the
holy things of the house of Yahweh for the Baals.[d] 8 At the king's order
a chest was made and placed outside the gate of Yahweh's house.
9 They announced throughout Judah and Jerusalem that the people
were to bring Yahweh the levy that Moses the servant of God had
imposed on Israel in the desert. 10 All the princes and all the people
rejoiced, and brought in, and cast into the chest, until they had made
an end. 11 Whenever the chest was brought to the king's officers by the
hand of the Levites, and when they saw that there was much money,
the king's scribe and the chief priest's officer came and emptied the
chest, and took it and carried it to its place again. Thus they did day
by day, and gathered money in abundance. 12 The king and Jehoiada

gave the money to the men in charge of the work on Yahweh's house. They hired stonemasons and carpenters to restore it, and also metal-workers in iron and bronze to repair it. 13 So the workmen wrought, and the work of repairing went forward in their hands; and they set up the house of God in its state, and strengthened it. 14 When they had finished, they brought the rest of the money before the king and Jehoiada, of which were made vessels for the house of Yahweh, vessels to minister and to offer, and spoons, and vessels of gold and silver. And they offered burnt offerings in the house of Yahweh continually all the days of Jehoiada.[e]

15 But Jehoiada grew old and full of days, and he died; he was a hundred and thirty years old at his death.[f] 16 And they buried him in the city of David among the kings, because he had done good in Israel, and toward God and his house.

17 Now after the death of Jehoiada the princes of Judah came and paid homage to the king. Then the king listened to them. 18 And they forsook the house of Yahweh, the God of their fathers, and served the Asherim and the idols. And wrath came upon Judah and Jerusalem for this guilt of theirs. 19 Yet he sent prophets among them to bring them back to Yahweh. These testified against them, but they would not give ear. 20 Then the Spirit of God clothed Zechariah the son of Jehoiada the priest; and he stood above the people and said to them, "God says this: 'Why do you disobey the commandments of Yahweh, so that you cannot prosper? Because you have forsaken Yahweh, he has also forsaken you.'"[g] 21 They conspired against him, and stoned him with stones at the commandment of the king in the court of the house of Yahweh. 22 Thus Joash the king remembered not the kindness which Jehoiada his father had done to him, but slew his son. And when he died, he said, "Yahweh look upon it and require it."[h]

23 At the turn of the year the army of the Arameans came up against Joash. They came to Judah and Jerusalem and destroyed all the princes of the people from among the people, and sent all their spoil to the king of Damascus.[i] 24 Although the Aramean army had come with only a few men, Yahweh handed over a much larger army to them, because Judah had abandoned Yahweh, the God of their

ancestors. So judgment was carried out on Joash. 25 When they were departed from him (for they left him very sick), his own servants conspired against him for the blood of the sons of Jehoiada the priest, and slew him on his bed, and he died. They buried him in the city of David, but they buried him not in the sepulchres of the kings.[j] 26 Those who conspired against him were Zabad the son of Shimeath the Ammonitess, and Jehozabad the son of Shimrith the Moabitess.[k] 27 The account of his sons, the many prophecies against him, and the rebuilding of God's house is written in the commentary on the book of the kings. His son Amaziah succeeded him as king.[l]

Notes

- a (24:1) Joash, also Jehoash; see 18:25. Zibiah, "gazelle." Verses 1–14 parallel 2 Kings 12:1–16, which describes the collection somewhat differently.
- b (24:4) Hebrew "it was in the heart of Joash."
- c (24:6) Compare Exodus 30:12–16, the half-shekel tax (about 0.2 ounce, 5.7 grams of silver).
- d (24:7) Hebrew "her sons"; perhaps her followers. Or "had broken up the house of God."
- e (24:14) Hebrew "spoons," small vessels or pans for incense. Second Kings 12:13 says the money was not used for vessels; Chronicles may refer to the surplus after repairs.
- f (24:15) Jehoiada's age (130) exceeds that of Moses and Aaron.
- g (24:20) Hebrew "clothed himself with Zechariah"; compare Judges 6:34. Zechariah, see 17:7. Jesus appears to refer to this martyrdom in Matthew 23:35 and Luke 11:51, where Matthew calls him "son of Barachiah" (compare Zechariah 1:1).
- h (24:22) Or "May Yahweh see and avenge." Jehoiada was Zechariah's father. Compare 2 Kings 12:17–18, which describes the Aramean threat and tribute.
- i (24:23) That is, in the spring, when kings went to war (1 Chronicles 20:1).
- j (24:25) Hebrew "sons"; the Septuagint reads "son." Second Kings 12:20–21 places his death at the house of Millo.
- k (24:26) Zabad, "he has bestowed" (2 Kings 12:21 Jozacar, "Yahweh has remembered"); Shimeath, "hearing"; Jehozabad, see 17:18; Shimrith, "guardian" (2 Kings 12:21 Shomer, "guardian," a man's name). Ammonitess and Moabitess are not in Kings.
- l (24:27) The Ketiv and Qere differ slightly in spelling the word for "many." Amaziah, "Yahweh is strong."

Chapter 25

1 Amaziah was twenty-five years old when he began to reign, and
he reigned twenty-nine years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was
Jehoaddan of Jerusalem.[a] 2 He did that which was right in the eyes of
Yahweh, yet not with a perfect heart. 3 Now when the kingdom was
established to him, he slew his servants who had slain the king his
father. 4 But he did not put their children to death, but did according
to that which is written in the law in the book of Moses, as Yahweh
commanded, saying, "The fathers shall not die for the children, nor
shall the children die for the fathers; but every man shall die for his
own sin."[b]
5 Moreover Amaziah gathered Judah together and ordered them
according to their fathers' houses, under captains of thousands and
captains of hundreds, all Judah and Benjamin. He numbered them
from twenty years old and upward, and found them three hundred
thousand chosen men, able to go forth to war, that could handle spear
and shield. 6 He hired also a hundred thousand mighty men of valor
out of Israel for about three and three-quarter tons of silver.[c] 7 But
there came a man of God to him, saying, "O king, let not the army of
Israel go with you; for Yahweh is not with Israel, with all the children
of Ephraim. 8 But if you will go, do it, be strong for the battle; God
will cast you down before the enemy, for God has power to help and
to cast down."[d] 9 Amaziah said to the man of God, "But what about the
silver I have given to the Israelite troops?" The man of God replied,
"Yahweh is able to give you much more than that." 10 Then Amaziah
separated them, the troops that had come to him out of Ephraim, to
go home again. And their anger was greatly kindled against Judah,
and they returned home in fierce anger.
11 Amaziah took courage and led forth his people, and went to the
Valley of Salt, and smote of the children of Seir ten thousand.[e] 12 And
the children of Judah carried away alive another ten thousand, and
brought them to the top of the rock, and cast them down from the
top of the rock, so that they all were broken in pieces.[f] 13 But the men
of the troops whom Amaziah sent back, that they should not go with

him to battle, fell upon the cities of Judah, from Samaria even to Beth-horon, and smote of them three thousand, and took much plunder.[g]
14 When Amaziah came home after defeating the Edomites, he brought
back the gods of the people of Seir and set them up as his own gods.
He bowed down to them and burned incense to them. 15 Therefore the
anger of Yahweh was kindled against Amaziah, and he sent to him a
prophet, who said to him, "Why have you sought after the gods of the
people, which have not delivered their own people out of your hand?"
16 And as he talked with him, the king said to him, "Have we made you
of the king's counsel? Forbear; why should you be smitten?" Then
the prophet forbore, and said, "I know that God has determined to
destroy you, because you have done this and have not hearkened to
my counsel."[h]
17 Then Amaziah king of Judah took counsel and sent to Joash, the
son of Jehoahaz, the son of Jehu, king of Israel, saying, "Come, let
us look one another in the face."[i] 18 And Joash king of Israel sent to
Amaziah king of Judah, saying, "The thistle that was in Lebanon sent
to the cedar that was in Lebanon, saying, 'Give your daughter to my
son as wife'; and there passed by a wild beast that was in Lebanon
and trod down the thistle.[j] 19 You say, 'See, I have smitten Edom,' and
your heart lifts you up to boast. Abide now at home; why should
you meddle to your hurt, that you should fall, even you, and Judah
with you?"[k] 20 But Amaziah would not hear; for it was of God, that
he might deliver them into the hand of their enemies, because they
had sought after the gods of Edom. 21 So Joash king of Israel went up,
and he and Amaziah king of Judah looked one another in the face at
Beth-shemesh, which belongs to Judah.[l] 22 And Judah was put to the
worse before Israel, and they fled every man to his tent. 23 And Joash
king of Israel took Amaziah king of Judah, the son of Joash, the son of
Jehoahaz, at Beth-shemesh, and brought him to Jerusalem, and broke
down the wall of Jerusalem from the gate of Ephraim to the corner
gate, six hundred feet.[m] 24 And he took all the gold and silver, and all
the vessels that were found in the house of God with Obed-edom,
and the treasures of the king's house, and the hostages, and returned
to Samaria.[n]

25 Amaziah the son of Joash king of Judah lived after the death of Joash
son of Jehoahaz king of Israel fifteen years. 26 Now the rest of the acts
of Amaziah, first and last, behold, are they not written in the book
of the kings of Judah and Israel? 27 Now from the time that Amaziah
turned away from following Yahweh, they made a conspiracy against
him in Jerusalem; and he fled to Lachish, but they sent after him to
Lachish and slew him there.[o] 28 And they brought him upon horses
and buried him with his fathers in the city of Judah.[p]

Notes

- a (25:1) Amaziah, see 24:27; Jehoaddan, "Yahweh is delight." Verses 1–4 parallel 2 Kings 14:1–6; verses 17–28 parallel 2 Kings 14:8–20.
- b (25:4) Deuteronomy 24:16.
- c (25:6) About 3.75 tons (3,400 kilograms) of silver. Hebrew "a hundred talents"; a talent was about 75 pounds or 34 kilograms. Verses 5–16 are not in Kings.
- d (25:8) The Hebrew is difficult; some read "if you go thinking to be strong for the battle, God will cast you down."
- e (25:11) The Valley of Salt, probably south of the Dead Sea; compare 2 Kings 14:7, which says Amaziah also took Sela ("rock").
- f (25:12) "The rock," Hebrew sela', perhaps the Edomite stronghold Sela (2 Kings 14:7).
- g (25:13) Beth-horon, "house of the hollow."
- h (25:16) The play on words: "counsel" (Hebrew ya'ats) runs through verses 16–17.
- i (25:17) Joash king of Israel, also Jehoash; Jehoahaz, see 21:17; Jehu, see 19:2. The Ketiv has an extra word, "to you" or "go," differing from the Qere.
- j (25:18) Lebanon, "white," for its snowy peaks.
- k (25:19) Hebrew "You say, 'Behold, you have smitten Edom'"; compare 2 Kings 14:10.
- l (25:21) Beth-shemesh, "house of the sun."
- m (25:23) Hebrew "four hundred cubits," about 600 feet or 180 meters; a cubit was about 18 inches or 45 centimeters.
- n (25:24) Obed-edom, "servant of Edom"; a family of gatekeepers (1 Chronicles 26:15). This detail is not in Kings.
- o (25:27) Lachish, meaning uncertain.
- p (25:28) The Septuagint, and 2 Kings 14:20, read "in the city of David."

Chapter 26

1 All the people of Judah took Uzziah, who was sixteen years old, and
made him king in the place of his father Amaziah.[a] 2 He built Eloth
and restored it to Judah, after the king slept with his fathers.[b]

3 Uzziah was sixteen years old when he began to reign, and he
reigned fifty-two years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Jecoliah
of Jerusalem.[c] 4 He did that which was right in the eyes of Yahweh,
according to all that his father Amaziah had done. 5 He set himself
to seek God in the days of Zechariah, who had understanding in the
vision of God; and as long as he sought Yahweh, God made him to
prosper.[d]
6 He went forth and warred against the Philistines, and broke down
the wall of Gath, the wall of Jabneh, and the wall of Ashdod; and
he built cities in the country of Ashdod and among the Philistines.[e] 7
God helped him against the Philistines, and against the Arabians who
dwelt in Gur-baal, and the Meunim.[f] 8 The Ammonites gave tribute
to Uzziah, and his name spread abroad even to the entrance of Egypt,
for he became exceedingly strong. 9 Moreover Uzziah built towers in
Jerusalem at the corner gate, at the valley gate, and at the turning of
the wall, and fortified them. 10 He also built towers in the desert and
dug many cisterns, since he owned large herds in the foothills and on
the plain. He employed farmers and vinedressers in the hills and in
the fertile fields, because he loved farming.[g]
11 Moreover Uzziah had an army of fighting men that went out to
war by bands, according to the number of their muster made by Jeiel
the scribe and Maaseiah the officer, under the hand of Hananiah, one
of the king's captains.[h] 12 The whole number of the heads of fathers'
houses, mighty men of valor, was two thousand six hundred. 13 Under
their hand was an army, three hundred and seven thousand five
hundred, that made war with mighty power, to help the king against
the enemy. 14 Uzziah prepared for them, for all the army, shields
and spears and helmets and coats of mail and bows and stones for
slinging. 15 And in Jerusalem he made engines, invented by skilful
men, to be on the towers and on the battlements, to shoot arrows and
great stones. And his name spread far abroad, for he was marvelously
helped till he was strong.[i]
16 But when he was strong, his heart was lifted up, so that he did
corruptly, and he trespassed against Yahweh his God; for he went into
the temple of Yahweh to burn incense upon the altar of incense.[j] 17

And Azariah the priest went in after him, and with him eighty priests of Yahweh, who were valiant men.[k] 18 They withstood Uzziah the king and said to him, "It pertains not to you, Uzziah, to burn incense to Yahweh, but to the priests the sons of Aaron, who are consecrated to burn incense. Go out of the sanctuary, for you have trespassed; neither shall it be for your honor from Yahweh God."[l] 19 Then Uzziah was wroth; and he had a censer in his hand to burn incense. And while he was wroth with the priests, a skin disease broke forth in his forehead before the priests in the house of Yahweh, beside the altar of incense.[m] 20 And Azariah the chief priest and all the priests looked upon him, and behold, he was diseased in his forehead, and they thrust him out quickly from there; yes, he himself also hasted to go out, because Yahweh had smitten him. 21 And Uzziah the king was diseased in his skin to the day of his death, and dwelt in a separate house, being so diseased; for he was cut off from the house of Yahweh. And Jotham his son was over the king's house, judging the people of the land.[n]

22 Now the rest of the acts of Uzziah, first and last, Isaiah the prophet, the son of Amoz, wrote.[o] 23 So Uzziah slept with his fathers, and they buried him with his fathers in the field of burial which belonged to the kings; for they said, "He is diseased in his skin." And Jotham his son reigned in his place.[p]

Notes

- a (26:1) Uzziah, "Yahweh is my strength"; called Azariah ("Yahweh has helped") in 2 Kings 14:21; 15:1–7 and 1 Chronicles 3:12. Verses 1–4 parallel 2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:2–3.
- b (26:2) Eloth, also Elath, "terebinths" or "palms," at the head of the Gulf of Aqaba.
- c (26:3) Jecoliah, "Yahweh is able." The Ketiv and Qere differ slightly in spelling the name.
- d (26:5) Zechariah, see 17:7. Hebrew "in the seeing of God"; the Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts read "in the fear of God," which differs by vowels and one letter.
- e (26:6) Gath, "winepress"; Jabneh, "he builds" (later Jamnia); Ashdod, meaning uncertain.
- f (26:7) Gur-baal, perhaps "dwelling of Baal"; the Septuagint reads "on the rock." Meunim, compare 20:1 note; the Septuagint reads "Minaeans." The Ketiv and Qere differ in spelling "Arabians."

- g (26:10) Hebrew "the Shephelah," the low hills west of Judah. Or "for he loved the land."
- h (26:11) Jeiel, see 20:14 (Ketiv Jeuel); Maaseiah, see 23:1; Hananiah, "Yahweh has been gracious."
- i (26:15) Perhaps catapults, or protective structures on the walls from which archers and slingers could shoot.
- j (26:16) Verses 16–21 expand on 2 Kings 15:5, which does not give the cause of the disease.
- k (26:17) Azariah, see 15:1.
- l (26:18) Compare Numbers 16:40; 18:1–7.
- m (26:19) Hebrew tsara'at, a term for various skin diseases (not necessarily modern leprosy), which made a person ritually unclean (Leviticus 13). Older versions, "leprosy."
- n (26:21) Hebrew "a house of freedom," perhaps a house of quarantine or release from duties; the Ketiv and Qere differ in spelling. Jotham, "Yahweh is perfect."
- o (26:22) Isaiah, "Yahweh is salvation"; Amoz, "strong." Compare Isaiah 1:1; 6:1. This writing is not otherwise known.
- p (26:23) Hebrew "He is diseased" (metsora'). Compare 2 Kings 15:7.

Chapter 27

1 Jotham was twenty-five years old when he began to reign, and he
reigned sixteen years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Jerushah
the daughter of Zadok.[a] 2 He did that which was right in the eyes of
Yahweh, according to all that his father Uzziah had done; however,
he did not enter into the temple of Yahweh. And the people still did
corruptly.[b] 3 He built the upper gate of the house of Yahweh, and on
the wall of Ophel he built much.[c] 4 Moreover he built cities in the hill
country of Judah, and in the forests he built fortresses and towers. 5
He fought also with the king of the children of Ammon and prevailed
against them. And the children of Ammon gave him the same year
about three and three-quarter tons of silver, and sixty thousand
bushels of wheat, and sixty thousand of barley. So much did the
children of Ammon pay him, both the second year and the third.[d] 6 So
Jotham became mighty, because he ordered his ways before Yahweh
his God.
7 Now the rest of the acts of Jotham, and all his wars and his ways,
behold, they are written in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah.
8 He was twenty-five years old when he began to reign, and reigned

sixteen years in Jerusalem. 9 And Jotham slept with his fathers, and they buried him in the city of David; and Ahaz his son reigned in his place.[e]

Notes

- a (27:1) Jerushah, "possessed"; Zadok, "righteous." Chapter 27 parallels 2 Kings 15:32–38.
- b (27:2) That is, he did not presume to burn incense as Uzziah had (26:16).
- c (27:3) Ophel, "swelling" or "hill," the fortified ridge south of the temple.
- d (27:5) About 3.75 tons (3,400 kilograms) of silver, and about 60,000 bushels (2,200,000 liters) each of wheat and barley. Hebrew "a hundred talents ... ten thousand cors"; a cor was about 6 bushels or 220 liters.
- e (27:9) Ahaz, "he has grasped."

Chapter 28

1 Ahaz was twenty years old when he began to reign, and he reigned sixteen years in Jerusalem. And he did not that which was right in the eyes of Yahweh, like David his father,[a] 2 but he walked in the ways of the kings of Israel, and made also molten images for the Baals. 3 Moreover he burned incense in the valley of the son of Hinnom, and burned his children in the fire, according to the abominations of the nations whom Yahweh cast out before the children of Israel.[b] 4 He sacrificed also and burned incense in the high places, and on the hills, and under every green tree.

5 Therefore Yahweh his God delivered him into the hand of the king of Aram; and they smote him and carried away of his a great multitude of captives and brought them to Damascus. And he was also delivered into the hand of the king of Israel, who smote him with a great slaughter.[c] 6 For Pekah the son of Remaliah slew in Judah a hundred and twenty thousand in one day, all valiant men, because they had forsaken Yahweh, the God of their fathers.[d] 7 And Zichri, a mighty man of Ephraim, slew Maaseiah the king's son, and Azrikam the ruler of the house, and Elkanah who was next to the king.[e] 8 The children of Israel carried away captive of their brothers two hundred thousand women, sons, and daughters, and took also much plunder from them, and brought the plunder to Samaria.

9 But a prophet of Yahweh was there, whose name was Oded; and he
went out to meet the army that came to Samaria, and said to them,
"Behold, because Yahweh, the God of your fathers, was wroth with
Judah, he has delivered them into your hand, and you have slain them
in a rage that has reached up to heaven.[f] 10 And now you purpose
to keep under the children of Judah and Jerusalem for bondmen and
bondwomen to yourselves. But are there not with you, even with you,
trespasses of your own against Yahweh your God? 11 Now hear me
therefore, and send back the captives whom you have taken captive
of your brothers; for the fierce wrath of Yahweh is upon you." 12 Then
certain of the heads of the children of Ephraim, Azariah the son of
Johanan, Berechiah the son of Meshillemoth, Jehizkiah the son of
Shallum, and Amasa the son of Hadlai, stood up against those who
came from the war,[g] 13 and said to them, "You shall not bring in
the captives here; for you purpose that which will bring upon us a
trespass against Yahweh, to add to our sins and to our trespass; for
our trespass is great, and there is fierce wrath against Israel." 14 So the
armed men left the captives and the plunder before the princes and
all the assembly. 15 And the men who have been expressed by name
rose up and took the captives, and with the plunder clothed all who
were naked among them, and arrayed them, and shod them, and gave
them to eat and to drink, and anointed them, and carried all the feeble
of them upon donkeys, and brought them to Jericho, the city of palm
trees, to their brothers. Then they returned to Samaria.[h]
16 At that time King Ahaz sent to the kings of Assyria to help him.[i] 17
For again the Edomites had come and smitten Judah and carried away
captives. 18 The Philistines had also raided the towns in the foothills
and the Negev of Judah. They captured Beth-shemesh, Aijalon,
Gederoth, and Soco with their villages, and Timnah and Gimzo with
their villages, and settled there.[j] 19 For Yahweh brought Judah low
because of Ahaz king of Israel; for he had dealt wantonly in Judah
and trespassed sorely against Yahweh.[k] 20 And Tilgath-pilneser king
of Assyria came to him and distressed him, but did not strengthen
him.[l] 21 For Ahaz took away a portion out of the house of Yahweh, and

out of the house of the king and of the princes, and gave it to the king of Assyria; but it did not help him.[m]
22 And in the time of his distress he trespassed yet more against
Yahweh, this same King Ahaz. 23 For he sacrificed to the gods of
Damascus, which smote him; and he said, "Because the gods of the
kings of Aram helped them, so will I sacrifice to them, that they may
help me." But they were the ruin of him and of all Israel.[n] 24 And Ahaz
gathered together the vessels of the house of God, and cut in pieces
the vessels of the house of God, and shut up the doors of the house
of Yahweh; and he made himself altars in every corner of Jerusalem.[o]
25 And in every city of Judah he made high places to burn incense to
other gods, and provoked to anger Yahweh, the God of his fathers. 26
Now the rest of his acts and all his ways, first and last, behold, they
are written in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel. 27 Ahaz slept
with his fathers, and they buried him in the city, even in Jerusalem,
because they brought him not into the sepulchres of the kings of
Israel; and Hezekiah his son reigned in his place.[p]

Notes

- a (28:1) Ahaz, see 27:9. Verses 1–4 parallel 2 Kings 16:1–4. On his age and his son Hezekiah's age (29:1), see 2 Kings 16:2 and 18:2; the figures are notoriously difficult to harmonize.
- b (28:3) Hinnom, meaning uncertain; the valley south of Jerusalem (later Gehenna). Hebrew "burned his sons"; 2 Kings 16:3 reads "made his son pass through the fire."
- c (28:5) Compare 2 Kings 16:5–6 and Isaiah 7:1–9, which describe the joint Aramean–Israelite attack (the Syro-Ephraimite war) without reporting a defeat in battle.
- d (28:6) Pekah, "opening (of the eyes)"; Remaliah, perhaps "Yahweh has adorned." Verses 6–15 are not in Kings; on the large numbers, see 13:3 note.
- e (28:7) Zichri, see 17:16; Maaseiah, see 23:1; Azrikam, "my help has arisen"; Elkanah, "God has created" or "acquired."
- f (28:9) Oded, see 15:1.
- g (28:12) Azariah, see 15:1; Johanan, "Yahweh is gracious"; Berechiah, "Yahweh blesses"; Meshillemoth, "recompense"; Jehizkiah, "Yahweh strengthens" (a form of Hezekiah); Shallum, "recompense"; Amasa, "burden"; Hadlai, "resting."
- h (28:15) Jericho, perhaps "moon city" or "fragrant." Compare Luke 10:30–37.
- i (28:16) Hebrew "kings"; the Septuagint reads "king." Compare 2 Kings 16:7, which names Tiglath-pileser.

- j (28:18) Negev, “south” or “dry land.” Aijalon, “place of deer”; Gederoth, “walls” or “sheepfolds”; Soco, “thorny”; Timnah, “portion”; Gimzo, perhaps “place of sycamores.”
- k (28:19) “King of Israel” here means king of Judah; compare 21:2 note. The Septuagint reads “king of Judah.”
- l (28:20) Tilgath-pilneser, the Chronicler’s spelling of Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria (reigned about 745–727 BC); Hebrew tukulti-apil-esharra, “my trust is the son of Esharra.” Second Kings 16:9 says he did help Ahaz by taking Damascus; Chronicles stresses that the help brought Judah no lasting good.
- m (28:21) Compare 2 Kings 16:8, 17–18.
- n (28:23) Second Kings 16:10–16 says Ahaz copied an altar he saw in Damascus.
- o (28:24) Second Kings 16:17–18 describes his removal of temple fixtures; the closing of the temple doors is reported only here (compare 29:3, 7).
- p (28:27) Second Kings 16:20 says Ahaz was buried with his fathers in the city of David. Hezekiah, “Yahweh strengthens.”

Chapter 29

1 Hezekiah began to reign when he was twenty-five years old, and
he reigned twenty-nine years in Jerusalem. His mother’s name was
Abijah the daughter of Zechariah.[a] 2 He did that which was right in
the eyes of Yahweh, according to all that David his father had done.
3 In the first year of his reign, in the first month (in March–April), he
opened the doors of the house of Yahweh and repaired them.[b] 4 He
brought in the priests and the Levites and gathered them together
into the broad place on the east, 5 and said to them, “Hear me, you
Levites! Sanctify now yourselves, and sanctify the house of Yahweh,
the God of your fathers, and carry forth the filthiness out of the
holy place.[c] 6 For our fathers have trespassed and done that which
was evil in the sight of Yahweh our God, and have forsaken him, and
have turned away their faces from the dwelling place of Yahweh, and
turned their backs. 7 Also they have shut up the doors of the porch
and put out the lamps, and have not burned incense nor offered burnt
offerings in the holy place to the God of Israel. 8 Therefore the wrath
of Yahweh was upon Judah and Jerusalem, and he has delivered them
to be a terror, an astonishment, and a hissing, as you see with your
eyes.[d] 9 For lo, our fathers have fallen by the sword, and our sons and
our daughters and our wives are in captivity for this. 10 Now it is in
my heart to make a covenant with Yahweh, the God of Israel, that his

fierce anger may turn away from us. 11 My sons, be not now negligent;
for Yahweh has chosen you to stand before him, to minister to him,
and that you should be his ministers and burn incense."
12 Then the Levites arose: Mahath the son of Amasai and Joel the son
of Azariah, of the sons of the Kohathites; and of the sons of Merari,
Kish the son of Abdi and Azariah the son of Jehallelel; and of the
Gershonites, Joah the son of Zimmah and Eden the son of Joah;[e] 13 and
of the sons of Elizaphan, Shimri and Jeiel; and of the sons of Asaph,
Zechariah and Mattaniah;[f] 14 and of the sons of Heman, Jehiel and
Shimei; and of the sons of Jeduthun, Shemaiah and Uzziel.[g] 15 And
they gathered their brothers and sanctified themselves, and went in,
according to the commandment of the king by the words of Yahweh,
to cleanse the house of Yahweh. 16 And the priests went into the inner
part of the house of Yahweh to cleanse it, and brought out all the
uncleanness that they found in the temple of Yahweh into the court
of the house of Yahweh; and the Levites took it to carry it out to the
brook Kidron. 17 Now they began on the first day of the first month
(in March–April) to sanctify, and on the eighth day of the month
they came to the porch of Yahweh; and they sanctified the house of
Yahweh in eight days, and on the sixteenth day of the first month
they made an end.[h]
18 Then they went in to Hezekiah the king within the palace and said,
"We have cleansed all the house of Yahweh, and the altar of burnt
offering with all its vessels, and the table of showbread with all its
vessels. 19 Moreover, all the vessels which King Ahaz in his reign
cast away when he trespassed, we have prepared and sanctified; and
behold, they are before the altar of Yahweh."
20 Then Hezekiah the king rose early and gathered the princes of
the city, and went up to the house of Yahweh. 21 And they brought
seven bullocks, seven rams, seven lambs, and seven he-goats, for a
sin offering for the kingdom, for the sanctuary, and for Judah. And
he commanded the priests the sons of Aaron to offer them on the
altar of Yahweh. 22 So they killed the bullocks, and the priests received
the blood and sprinkled it on the altar; and they killed the rams
and sprinkled the blood on the altar; they killed also the lambs and

sprinkled the blood on the altar. 23 And they brought near the he-goats
for the sin offering before the king and the assembly, and they laid
their hands upon them. 24 And the priests killed them, and they made
a sin offering with their blood upon the altar, to make atonement for
all Israel; for the king commanded that the burnt offering and the
sin offering should be made for all Israel.[i] 25 And he set the Levites in
the house of Yahweh with cymbals, with psalteries, and with harps,
according to the commandment of David, and of Gad the king's seer,
and of Nathan the prophet; for the commandment was of Yahweh by
his prophets.[j] 26 And the Levites stood with the instruments of David,
and the priests with the trumpets. 27 And Hezekiah commanded to
offer the burnt offering upon the altar. And when the burnt offering
began, the song of Yahweh began also, with the trumpets, together
with the instruments of David king of Israel. 28 And all the assembly
worshiped, and the singers sang, and the trumpeters sounded; all this
continued until the burnt offering was finished. 29 And when they had
made an end of offering, the king and all that were present with him
bowed themselves and worshiped. 30 Moreover Hezekiah the king and
the princes commanded the Levites to sing praises to Yahweh with
the words of David and of Asaph the seer. And they sang praises with
gladness, and they bowed their heads and worshiped.
31 Then Hezekiah answered and said, "Now you have consecrated
yourselves to Yahweh; come near and bring sacrifices and thank
offerings into the house of Yahweh." And the assembly brought in
sacrifices and thank offerings, and as many as were of a willing heart
brought burnt offerings.[k] 32 The number of the burnt offerings which
the assembly brought was seventy bullocks, a hundred rams, and two
hundred lambs; all these were for a burnt offering to Yahweh. 33 And
the consecrated things were six hundred oxen and three thousand
sheep. 34 But the priests were too few, so that they could not flay all
the burnt offerings; wherefore their brothers the Levites helped them
till the work was ended, and until the other priests had sanctified
themselves; for the Levites were more upright in heart to sanctify
themselves than the priests. 35 And also the burnt offerings were in
abundance, with the fat of the peace offerings and with the drink

offerings for every burnt offering. So the service of the house of Yahweh was set in order. 36 And Hezekiah rejoiced, and all the people, because of that which God had prepared for the people; for the thing was done suddenly.

Notes

- a (29:1) Hezekiah, see 28:27. Abijah, "Yahweh is my father" (2 Kings 18:2 Abi); Zechariah, see 17:7. Compare 2 Kings 18:1–3. Chapters 29–31 are largely not in Kings.
- b (29:3) The first month, later Nisan, counting from the spring new year.
- c (29:5) Or "the impurity," anything defiling, such as idols or idol vessels.
- d (29:8) The Ketiv and Qere differ in spelling the word for "terror." Compare Jeremiah 29:18.
- e (29:12) Mahath, "snatching"; Amasai, "burden-bearer"; Joel, "Yahweh is God"; Azariah, see 15:1; Kohathites, see 20:19; Merari, "bitter"; Kish, perhaps "bow"; Abdi, "my servant"; Jehallelel, "he praises God"; Gershonites, from Gershon ("expulsion" or "sojourner"); Joah, "Yahweh is brother"; Zimmah, "purpose" or "plan"; Eden, "delight."
- f (29:13) Elizaphan, "God has hidden"; Shimri, "my guard"; Jeiel, see 20:14 (Ketiv Jeuel); Asaph and Mattaniah, see 20:14.
- g (29:14) Heman, "faithful"; Jehiel, see 21:2 (Ketiv Jehuel); Shimei, "heard"; Jeduthun, perhaps "praise"; Shemaiah, see 11:2; Uzziel, "God is my strength."
- h (29:17) The sixteenth day fell after the time appointed for Passover (fourteenth of the first month), which is why it was held in the second month (30:2).
- i (29:24) "All Israel" includes the northern tribes; compare 30:1.
- j (29:25) Gad, "fortune"; Nathan, "he has given." Compare 1 Chronicles 23–25.
- k (29:31) Hebrew "Now you have filled your hand," an idiom for ordination.

Chapter 30

1 Hezekiah sent to all Israel and Judah, and wrote letters also to Ephraim and Manasseh, that they should come to the house of Yahweh at Jerusalem, to keep the Passover to Yahweh, the God of Israel.[a] 2 For the king had taken counsel, and his princes and all the assembly in Jerusalem, to keep the Passover in the second month (in April–May).[b] 3 For they could not keep it at that time, because the priests had not sanctified themselves in sufficient number, neither had the people gathered themselves together to Jerusalem. 4 And the thing was right in the eyes of the king and of all the assembly. 5 So they established a decree to make proclamation throughout all Israel, from

Beersheba even to Dan, that they should come to keep the Passover to Yahweh, the God of Israel, at Jerusalem; for they had not kept it in great numbers in such sort as it is written.[c]
6 So the posts went with the letters from the king and his princes throughout all Israel and Judah, and according to the commandment of the king, saying, "You children of Israel, turn again to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, that he may return to the remnant that are escaped of you out of the hand of the kings of Assyria.[d] 7 And be not like your fathers and like your brothers, who trespassed against Yahweh, the God of their fathers, so that he gave them up to desolation, as you see. 8 Now be not stiffnecked, as your fathers were, but yield yourselves to Yahweh, and enter into his sanctuary, which he has sanctified forever, and serve Yahweh your God, that his fierce anger may turn away from you.[e] 9 For if you turn again to Yahweh, your brothers and your children shall find compassion before those who led them captive, and shall come again into this land; for Yahweh your God is gracious and merciful, and will not turn away his face from you, if you return to him."
10 So the posts passed from city to city through the country of Ephraim and Manasseh, even to Zebulun; but they laughed them to scorn and mocked them.[f] 11 Nevertheless certain men of Asher and Manasseh and of Zebulun humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem.[g] 12 Also in Judah was the hand of God to give them one heart, to do the commandment of the king and of the princes by the word of Yahweh.
13 And there assembled at Jerusalem much people to keep the feast of unleavened bread in the second month (in April–May), a very great assembly. 14 And they arose and took away the altars that were in Jerusalem, and all the altars for incense they took away and cast them into the brook Kidron. 15 Then they killed the Passover on the fourteenth day of the second month (in April–May). And the priests and the Levites were ashamed, and sanctified themselves, and brought burnt offerings into the house of Yahweh.[h] 16 And they stood in their place after their order, according to the law of Moses the man of God; the priests sprinkled the blood, which they received of the hand of the Levites. 17 For there were many in the assembly who had not

sanctified themselves; therefore the Levites had the charge of killing the Passovers for everyone who was not clean, to sanctify them to Yahweh. 18 For a multitude of the people, even many of Ephraim and Manasseh, Issachar and Zebulun, had not cleansed themselves, yet did they eat the Passover otherwise than it is written. For Hezekiah had prayed for them, saying, "The good Yahweh pardon everyone[i] 19 who sets his heart to seek God, Yahweh, the God of his fathers, though he be not cleansed according to the purification of the sanctuary." 20 And Yahweh hearkened to Hezekiah and healed the people. 21 And the children of Israel that were present at Jerusalem kept the feast of unleavened bread seven days with great gladness; and the Levites and the priests praised Yahweh day by day, singing with loud instruments to Yahweh.[j] 22 And Hezekiah spoke to the heart of all the Levites that had good understanding in the service of Yahweh. So they did eat throughout the feast for the seven days, offering sacrifices of peace offerings and making confession to Yahweh, the God of their fathers.[k] 23 And the whole assembly took counsel to keep another seven days; and they kept another seven days with gladness. 24 For Hezekiah king of Judah gave to the assembly for offerings a thousand bullocks and seven thousand sheep; and the princes gave to the assembly a thousand bullocks and ten thousand sheep; and a great number of priests sanctified themselves. 25 And all the assembly of Judah, with the priests and the Levites, and all the assembly that came out of Israel, and the sojourners that came out of the land of Israel and that dwelt in Judah, rejoiced. 26 So there was great joy in Jerusalem; for since the time of Solomon the son of David king of Israel there was not the like in Jerusalem. 27 Then the priests the Levites arose and blessed the people; and their voice was heard, and their prayer came up to his holy dwelling place, even to heaven.

Notes

- a (30:1) Ephraim, see 13:4; Manasseh, see 15:9. Passover, Hebrew pesah.
- b (30:2) The second month, later Iyyar, counting from the spring new year. Numbers 9:6–13 permits a Passover in the second month for those who are unclean or far away.
- c (30:5) Dan, "judge." Or "for they had not kept it for a long time as it is written."

- d (30:6) Abraham, “father of a multitude”; Isaac, “he laughs”; Israel, “he strives with God.” The northern kingdom had fallen to Assyria (2 Kings 17).
- e (30:8) Hebrew “give the hand to Yahweh,” a gesture of submission.
- f (30:10) Zebulun, “dwelling” or “honor.”
- g (30:11) Asher, “happy.”
- h (30:15) Passover was the fourteenth day of the first month (Exodus 12:6); compare verse 2 note.
- i (30:18) Issachar, “there is reward.” The Septuagint joins “saying” to verse 19.
- j (30:21) The feast of unleavened bread, the fifteenth to the twenty-first of the month. Hebrew “with instruments of strength,” or read “with all their strength” (compare 1 Chronicles 13:8).
- k (30:22) Or “spoke encouragingly to.” Or “giving thanks to Yahweh.”

Chapter 31

1 Once all this was finished, all the Israelites who were present went out to the cities of Judah, broke the sacred pillars, cut down the Asherah poles, and tore down the high places and altars throughout Judah and Benjamin, and in Ephraim and Manasseh as well, until they had destroyed them all. Then all the Israelites went back to their own towns and properties.

2 And Hezekiah appointed the courses of the priests and the Levites after their courses, every man according to his service, both the priests and the Levites, for burnt offerings and for peace offerings, to minister, and to give thanks, and to praise in the gates of the camp of Yahweh.[a] 3 He appointed also the king’s portion of his substance for the burnt offerings, for the morning and evening burnt offerings, and the burnt offerings for the Sabbaths, and for the new moons, and for the set feasts, as it is written in the law of Yahweh. 4 Moreover he commanded the people that dwelt in Jerusalem to give the portion of the priests and the Levites, that they might give themselves to the law of Yahweh. 5 And as soon as the commandment came abroad, the children of Israel gave in abundance the firstfruits of grain, new wine, and oil, and honey, and of all the increase of the field; and the tithe of all things they brought in abundantly. 6 And the children of Israel and Judah, that dwelt in the cities of Judah, they also brought in the tithe of oxen and sheep, and the tithe of dedicated things which were consecrated to Yahweh their God, and laid them by heaps. 7 In

the third month (in May–June) they began to lay the foundation of the heaps, and finished them in the seventh month (in September–October).[b] 8 And when Hezekiah and the princes came and saw the heaps, they blessed Yahweh and his people Israel. 9 Then Hezekiah questioned with the priests and the Levites concerning the heaps. 10 And Azariah the chief priest, of the house of Zadok, answered him and said, "Since the people began to bring the offerings into the house of Yahweh, we have eaten and had enough, and have left plenty; for Yahweh has blessed his people, and that which is left is this great store."[c]
11 Then Hezekiah commanded to prepare chambers in the house of Yahweh, and they prepared them. 12 And they brought in the offerings and the tithes and the dedicated things faithfully; and over them Conaniah the Levite was ruler, and Shimei his brother was second.[d] 13 And Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismachiah, Mahath, and Benaiah were overseers under the hand of Conaniah and Shimei his brother, by the appointment of Hezekiah the king and Azariah the ruler of the house of God.[e] 14 And Kore the son of Imnah the Levite, the porter at the east gate, was over the freewill offerings of God, to distribute the offerings of Yahweh and the most holy things.[f] 15 And under him were Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah, in the cities of the priests, in their office of trust, to give to their brothers by courses, as well to the great as to the small;[g] 16 besides those reckoned by genealogy of males, from three years old and upward, even everyone that entered into the house of Yahweh, as the duty of every day required, for their service in their offices according to their courses;[h] 17 and those reckoned by genealogy of the priests by their fathers' houses, and the Levites from twenty years old and upward, in their offices by their courses; 18 and those reckoned by genealogy of all their little ones, their wives, and their sons and their daughters, throughout all the congregation; for in their office of trust they sanctified themselves in holiness. 19 Also for the sons of Aaron the priests, who were in the fields of the pasture lands of their cities, in every city there were men that were mentioned

by name, to give portions to all the males among the priests and to all that were reckoned by genealogy among the Levites.
20 And thus did Hezekiah throughout all Judah; and he wrought that which was good and right and faithful before Yahweh his God. 21 And in every work that he began in the service of the house of God, and in the law, and in the commandments, to seek his God, he did it with all his heart and prospered.

Notes

- a (31:2) "The camp of Yahweh," the temple precincts, recalling the wilderness camp.
- b (31:7) The third month, later Sivan, the time of the grain harvest and the Feast of Weeks; the seventh month, later Tishri, the time of the fruit harvest and the Feast of Booths. Counting from the spring new year.
- c (31:10) Azariah, see 15:1; Zadok, see 27:1.
- d (31:12) Conaniah, "Yahweh has established" (the Ketiv spells it Conaniahu); Shimei, see 29:14.
- e (31:13) Jehiel, see 21:2; Azaziah, "Yahweh is strong"; Nahath, "rest"; Asahel, see 17:8; Jerimoth, perhaps "heights"; Jozabad, "Yahweh has bestowed"; Eliel, "my God is God"; Ismachiah, "Yahweh supports"; Mahath, see 29:12; Benaiah, see 20:14.
- f (31:14) Kore, "partridge" or "one who calls"; Imnah, "good fortune."
- g (31:15) Eden, see 29:12; Miniamin, "from the right hand"; Jeshua, "Yahweh is salvation"; Shemaiah, see 11:2; Amariah, see 19:11; Shecaniah, "Yahweh dwells."
- h (31:16) The Hebrew and Septuagint read "three years"; some suggest "thirty years" (compare 1 Chronicles 23:3), since three-year-olds did not serve in the temple, but the phrase may refer to the families provided for.

Chapter 32

1 After these things and this faithfulness, Sennacherib king of Assyria came and entered into Judah and encamped against the fortified cities, and thought to win them for himself.[a] 2 And when Hezekiah saw that Sennacherib had come, and that he was purposed to fight against Jerusalem, 3 he took counsel with his princes and his mighty men to stop the waters of the springs which were outside the city; and they helped him. 4 So there was gathered much people together, and they stopped all the springs and the brook that flowed through the midst of the land, saying, "Why should the kings of Assyria come and find much water?"[b] 5 And he took courage and built up all the wall that was broken down, and raised it up to the towers, and another wall outside, and strengthened the Millo in the city of David, and

made weapons and shields in abundance.[c] 6 And he set captains of
war over the people, and gathered them together to him in the broad
place at the gate of the city, and spoke to their heart, saying, 7 "Be
strong and of good courage; be not afraid nor dismayed for the king
of Assyria, nor for all the multitude that is with him; for there is a
greater with us than with him.[d] 8 With him is an arm of flesh, but with
us is Yahweh our God to help us and to fight our battles." And the
people leaned upon the words of Hezekiah king of Judah.
9 After this Sennacherib king of Assyria sent his servants to Jerusalem
(now he was before Lachish, and all his power with him), to Hezekiah
king of Judah and to all Judah that were at Jerusalem, saying,[e] 10 "Thus
says Sennacherib king of Assyria: 'On what do you trust, that you
abide the siege in Jerusalem? 11 Does not Hezekiah persuade you, to
give you over to die by famine and by thirst, saying, "Yahweh our
God will deliver us out of the hand of the king of Assyria"? 12 Has
not the same Hezekiah taken away his high places and his altars, and
commanded Judah and Jerusalem, saying, "You shall worship before
one altar, and upon it shall you burn incense"?[f] 13 Know you not what
I and my fathers have done to all the peoples of the lands? Were the
gods of the nations of the lands in any way able to deliver their land
out of my hand? 14 Who was there among all the gods of those nations
which my fathers utterly destroyed, that could deliver his people out
of my hand, that your God should be able to deliver you out of my
hand? 15 Now therefore let not Hezekiah deceive you, nor persuade
you after this manner, neither believe him; for no god of any nation
or kingdom was able to deliver his people out of my hand and out of
the hand of my fathers. How much less shall your God deliver you
out of my hand!'" 16 And his servants spoke yet more against Yahweh
God and against his servant Hezekiah. 17 He wrote also letters to rail
on Yahweh, the God of Israel, and to speak against him, saying, "As
the gods of the nations of the lands, which have not delivered their
people out of my hand, so shall not the God of Hezekiah deliver his
people out of my hand." 18 And they cried with a loud voice in the
language of Judah to the people of Jerusalem that were on the wall,
to frighten them and to trouble them, that they might take the city.[g] 19

And they spoke of the God of Jerusalem as of the gods of the peoples of the earth, which are the work of men's hands.
20 And Hezekiah the king and Isaiah the prophet the son of Amoz prayed because of this, and cried to heaven.[h] 21 And Yahweh sent an angel, who cut off all the mighty men of valor, and the leaders and captains, in the camp of the king of Assyria. So he returned with shame of face to his own land. And when he had come into the house of his god, some of his own offspring slew him there with the sword.[i]
22 Thus Yahweh saved Hezekiah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem from the hand of Sennacherib the king of Assyria and from the hand of all others, and guided them on every side.[j] 23 And many brought gifts to Yahweh to Jerusalem, and precious things to Hezekiah king of Judah, so that he was exalted in the sight of all nations from then on.
24 In those days Hezekiah was sick unto death; and he prayed to Yahweh, and he spoke to him and gave him a sign.[k] 25 But Hezekiah rendered not again according to the benefit done to him, for his heart was lifted up; therefore there was wrath upon him, and upon Judah and Jerusalem. 26 Notwithstanding, Hezekiah humbled himself for the pride of his heart, both he and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, so that the wrath of Yahweh came not upon them in the days of Hezekiah.
27 And Hezekiah had exceedingly much riches and honor; and he provided himself treasuries for silver, and for gold, and for precious stones, and for spices, and for shields, and for all manner of goodly vessels; 28 storehouses also for the increase of grain and new wine and oil, and stalls for all manner of beasts, and flocks in folds.[l] 29 Moreover he provided himself cities, and possessions of flocks and herds in abundance; for God had given him very much substance. 30 This same Hezekiah also stopped the upper outlet of the waters of Gihon and brought them straight down on the west side of the city of David. And Hezekiah prospered in all his works.[m] 31 However, in the business of the ambassadors of the princes of Babylon, who sent to him to inquire of the wonder that was done in the land, God left him, to try him, that he might know all that was in his heart.[n]
32 Now the rest of the acts of Hezekiah and his good deeds, behold, they are written in the vision of Isaiah the prophet the son of Amoz,

in the book of the kings of Judah and Israel. 33 And Hezekiah slept with his fathers, and they buried him in the ascent of the sepulchres of the sons of David; and all Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem did him honor at his death. And Manasseh his son reigned in his place.[o]

Notes

- a (32:1) Sennacherib, Akkadian Sin-ahhe-eriba, "(the god) Sin has replaced the brothers," king of Assyria about 705–681 BC; his invasion was in 701 BC. Chapter 32 condenses 2 Kings 18:13–20:21 (compare Isaiah 36–39). Chronicles omits Hezekiah's tribute payment (2 Kings 18:14–16).
- b (32:4) Or "the kings of Assyria," referring to the Assyrian kings generally; the Septuagint reads "the king of the Assyrians."
- c (32:5) The Millo, "filling," probably terraced fill or a fortification; compare 1 Chronicles 11:8.
- d (32:7) Compare 2 Kings 6:16.
- e (32:9) Lachish, see 25:27.
- f (32:12) Compare 2 Kings 18:22. From Sennacherib's viewpoint Hezekiah's reform (31:1) had offended Yahweh.
- g (32:18) Hebrew "Judean" (yehudit), the Hebrew dialect of Judah; compare 2 Kings 18:26–28.
- h (32:20) Isaiah, see 26:22. Compare 2 Kings 19:14–19; Isaiah 37:14–20.
- i (32:21) Second Kings 19:35 gives the number struck as 185,000. Sennacherib was assassinated in 681 BC, about twenty years later (2 Kings 19:37 names the sons Adrammelech and Sharezer). The Ketiv and Qere differ in spelling "offspring" (literally "those who came out of his bowels").
- j (32:22) The Septuagint reads "gave them rest on every side"; the Hebrew "guided them" (vayyenahalem) may be a miscopying of "gave them rest" (vayyanah lahem).
- k (32:24) Compare 2 Kings 20:1–11; Isaiah 38, where the sign is the shadow going back on the steps.
- l (32:28) Hebrew "flocks for folds," perhaps "folds for flocks."
- m (32:30) Gihon, "gushing," the spring in the Kidron valley. This is the tunnel known today as Hezekiah's Tunnel (about 1,750 feet or 533 meters long), with the Siloam Inscription; compare 2 Kings 20:20.
- n (32:31) Compare 2 Kings 20:12–19; Isaiah 39. Babylon, Hebrew Babel, popularly linked with "confusion" (Genesis 11:9); Akkadian bab-ili, "gate of god." The wonder was the sign of verse 24.
- o (32:33) Or "in the upper part of the tombs." Manasseh, see 15:9.

Chapter 33

1 Manasseh was twelve years old when he began to reign, and he reigned fifty-five years in Jerusalem.[a] 2 And he did that which was evil

in the sight of Yahweh, after the abominations of the nations whom
Yahweh cast out before the children of Israel. 3 He rebuilt the high
places that his father Hezekiah had torn down, set up altars for the
Baals, made Asherah poles, and worshiped all the stars of heaven
and served them. 4 And he built altars in the house of Yahweh, of
which Yahweh said, "In Jerusalem shall my name be forever." 5 And
he built altars for all the host of heaven in the two courts of the house
of Yahweh. 6 He also made his children to pass through the fire in
the valley of the son of Hinnom; and he practiced augury, and used
enchantments, and practiced sorcery, and dealt with those who had
familiar spirits and with wizards. He wrought much evil in the sight
of Yahweh, to provoke him to anger.[b] 7 And he set the carved image of
the idol, which he had made, in the house of God, of which God said to
David and to Solomon his son, "In this house, and in Jerusalem, which
I have chosen out of all the tribes of Israel, will I put my name forever;[c]
8 neither will I any more remove the foot of Israel from off the land
which I have appointed for your fathers, if only they will observe to
do all that I have commanded them, even all the law and the statutes
and the ordinances by the hand of Moses." 9 And Manasseh seduced
Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, so that they did evil more
than did the nations whom Yahweh destroyed before the children of
Israel.
10 And Yahweh spoke to Manasseh and to his people, but they gave no
heed. 11 So Yahweh brought the commanders of the king of Assyria's
army against them. They captured Manasseh with hooks, bound him
in shackles, and took him to Babylon.[d] 12 And when he was in distress,
he besought Yahweh his God, and humbled himself greatly before the
God of his fathers. 13 And he prayed to him; and he was entreated of
him and heard his supplication, and brought him again to Jerusalem
into his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that Yahweh, he is God.[e]
14 Now after this he built an outer wall to the city of David, on the
west side of Gihon, in the valley, even to the entrance at the fish gate;
and he compassed Ophel about with it and raised it up to a very great
height. And he put valiant captains in all the fortified cities of Judah.[f]
15 And he took away the foreign gods and the idol out of the house

of Yahweh, and all the altars that he had built in the mount of the house of Yahweh and in Jerusalem, and cast them out of the city. 16 And he built up the altar of Yahweh, and offered thereon sacrifices of peace offerings and of thanksgiving, and commanded Judah to serve Yahweh, the God of Israel.[g] 17 Nevertheless the people still sacrificed in the high places, but only to Yahweh their God.
18 Now the rest of the acts of Manasseh, and his prayer to his God, and the words of the seers that spoke to him in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel, behold, they are written among the acts of the kings of Israel.[h] 19 His prayer, and how God accepted his plea, and all his sin and unfaithfulness, and the sites where he built high places and set up Asherah poles and idols before he humbled himself, are written in the records of Hozai.[i] 20 So Manasseh slept with his fathers, and they buried him in his own house; and Amon his son reigned in his place.[j] 21 Amon was twenty-two years old when he began to reign, and he reigned two years in Jerusalem.[k] 22 And he did that which was evil in the sight of Yahweh, as did Manasseh his father; and Amon sacrificed to all the carved images which Manasseh his father had made, and served them. 23 And he humbled not himself before Yahweh, as Manasseh his father had humbled himself; but this same Amon trespassed more and more. 24 And his servants conspired against him and put him to death in his own house. 25 But the people of the land struck down everyone who had conspired against King Amon, and they made his son Josiah king in his place.[l]

Notes

- a (33:1) Verses 1–10 parallel 2 Kings 21:1–10; verses 18–25 parallel 2 Kings 21:17–24.
- b (33:6) Hebrew "his sons"; 2 Kings 21:6 "his son." "Familiar spirits," Hebrew 'ov, a medium or the spirit of a dead person consulted by a medium; compare Deuteronomy 18:10–11.
- c (33:7) Second Kings 21:7 specifies "the carved image of Asherah."
- d (33:11) Or "with nose hooks," as Assyrian reliefs show captives led. Manasseh's captivity and repentance (verses 11–17) are not in Kings, which blames him for the exile (2 Kings 21:10–16; 24:3–4). Assyrian records name Manasseh as a vassal of Esarhaddon and Ashurbanipal; Babylon was then under Assyrian rule.
- e (33:13) A later Jewish composition, the Prayer of Manasseh, preserved in some Greek Bibles and the Apocrypha, claims to be this prayer.

- f (33:14) Gihon, see 32:30; Ophel, see 27:3.
- g (33:16) The Ketiv reads "and he prepared," the Qere "and he built."
- h (33:18) Hebrew "the words of the kings of Israel," that is, their records.
- i (33:19) Hozai, "my seers," or read "the seers" (hozim) by a slight change; the Septuagint reads "the seers." Asherim, see 14:3.
- j (33:20) Second Kings 21:18 adds "in the garden of his house, in the garden of Uzza." Amon, see 18:25.
- k (33:21) Compare 2 Kings 21:19–26.
- l (33:25) Josiah, "Yahweh supports" or "Yahweh heals."

Chapter 34

1 Josiah was eight years old when he began to reign, and he reigned
thirty-one years in Jerusalem.[a] 2 And he did that which was right in
the eyes of Yahweh, and walked in the ways of David his father, and
turned not aside to the right hand nor to the left.
3 For in the eighth year of his reign, while he was yet young, he began
to seek after the God of David his father; and in the twelfth year he
began to purge Judah and Jerusalem from the high places, and the
Asherim, and the carved images, and the molten images.[b] 4 And they
broke down the altars of the Baals in his presence; and the incense
altars that were on high above them he hewed down; and the Asherim
and the carved images and the molten images he broke in pieces, and
made dust of them, and strewed it upon the graves of those who had
sacrificed to them.[c] 5 And he burned the bones of the priests upon their
altars, and purged Judah and Jerusalem.[d] 6 And so did he in the cities of
Manasseh and Ephraim and Simeon, even to Naphtali, in their ruins
round about.[e] 7 He tore down the altars, ground the Asherah poles
and idols to powder, and cut down all the incense altars throughout
the land of Israel. Then he returned to Jerusalem.
8 Now in the eighteenth year of his reign, when he had purged the
land and the house, he sent Shaphan the son of Azaliah, and Maaseiah
the governor of the city, and Joah the son of Joahaz the recorder, to
repair the house of Yahweh his God.[f] 9 And they came to Hilkiah the
high priest and delivered the money that was brought into the house
of God, which the Levites, the keepers of the threshold, had gathered
from the hand of Manasseh and Ephraim, and of all the remnant
of Israel, and of all Judah and Benjamin, and of the inhabitants of

Jerusalem.[g] 10 And they delivered it into the hand of the workmen
that had the oversight of the house of Yahweh; and the workmen that
wrought in the house of Yahweh gave it to mend and repair the house;
11 even to the carpenters and to the builders gave they it, to buy hewn
stone and timber for couplings, and to make beams for the houses
which the kings of Judah had destroyed. 12 And the men did the work
faithfully; and the overseers of them were Jahath and Obadiah, the
Levites, of the sons of Merari; and Zechariah and Meshullam, of the
sons of the Kohathites, to set it forward; and others of the Levites, all
that were skilful with instruments of music.[h] 13 Also they were over
the bearers of burdens, and set forward all that did the work in every
manner of service; and of the Levites there were scribes and officers
and porters.
14 And when they brought out the money that was brought into
the house of Yahweh, Hilkiah the priest found the book of the law
of Yahweh given by Moses.[i] 15 And Hilkiah answered and said to
Shaphan the scribe, "I have found the book of the law in the house of
Yahweh." And Hilkiah delivered the book to Shaphan. 16 And Shaphan
carried the book to the king, and moreover brought the king word
again, saying, "All that was committed to your servants, they are
doing. 17 And they have emptied out the money that was found in the
house of Yahweh, and have delivered it into the hand of the overseers
and into the hand of the workmen." 18 And Shaphan the scribe told
the king, saying, "Hilkiah the priest has delivered me a book." And
Shaphan read therein before the king. 19 And it came to pass, when
the king had heard the words of the law, that he tore his clothes. 20
And the king commanded Hilkiah, and Ahikam the son of Shaphan,
and Abdon the son of Micah, and Shaphan the scribe, and Asaiah the
king's servant, saying,[j] 21 "Go, inquire of Yahweh for me, and for those
who are left in Israel and in Judah, concerning the words of the book
that is found; for great is the wrath of Yahweh that is poured out
upon us, because our fathers have not kept the word of Yahweh, to
do according to all that is written in this book."
22 So Hilkiah and they whom the king had commanded went to Huldah
the prophetess, the wife of Shallum the son of Tokhath, the son of

Hasrah, keeper of the wardrobe (now she dwelt in Jerusalem in the second quarter); and they spoke to her to that effect.[k] 23 She told them, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: Tell the man who sent you to me, 24 Thus says Yahweh: Behold, I will bring evil upon this place and upon its inhabitants, even all the curses that are written in the book which they have read before the king of Judah. 25 Because they have forsaken me and have burned incense to other gods, that they might provoke me to anger with all the works of their hands, therefore is my wrath poured out upon this place, and it shall not be quenched.'[l] 26 But to the king of Judah, who sent you to inquire of Yahweh, thus shall you say to him: 'Thus says Yahweh, the God of Israel: As touching the words which you have heard, 27 because your heart was tender, and you humbled yourself before God when you heard his words against this place and against its inhabitants, and have humbled yourself before me, and have torn your clothes and wept before me, I also have heard you, says Yahweh. 28 Behold, I will gather you to your fathers, and you shall be gathered to your grave in peace, neither shall your eyes see all the evil that I will bring upon this place and upon its inhabitants.'" And they brought the king word again.[m]

29 Then the king sent and gathered together all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem. 30 And the king went up to the house of Yahweh, and all the men of Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and the priests and the Levites, and all the people, both great and small; and he read in their ears all the words of the book of the covenant that was found in the house of Yahweh. 31 And the king stood in his place and made a covenant before Yahweh, to walk after Yahweh, and to keep his commandments and his testimonies and his statutes with all his heart and with all his soul, to perform the words of the covenant that were written in this book. 32 And he caused all that were found in Jerusalem and Benjamin to stand to it. And the inhabitants of Jerusalem did according to the covenant of God, the God of their fathers. 33 And Josiah took away all the abominations out of all the countries that pertained to the children of Israel, and made all that were found in

Israel to serve, even to serve Yahweh their God. All his days they departed not from following Yahweh, the God of their fathers.

Notes

- a (34:1) Josiah, see 33:25. Chapters 34–35 parallel 2 Kings 22:1–23:30, but Chronicles places the purge (verses 3–7) before the finding of the book, whereas Kings places it after (2 Kings 23:4–20).
- b (34:3) The eighth year, when he was about sixteen; the twelfth year, about 628 BC.
- c (34:4) Hebrew hammanim; see 14:5 note.
- d (34:5) Compare 1 Kings 13:2; 2 Kings 23:16, 20. The Ketiv spells "their altars" with a double plural ending.
- e (34:6) The Ketiv reads, obscurely, "in the mountain, their houses"; the Qere, "with their swords" or (by slight change) "in their ruins." The Septuagint reads "and the places round about them." The sense is uncertain.
- f (34:8) Shaphan, "rock badger"; Azaliah, "Yahweh has reserved"; Maaseiah, see 23:1; Joah, see 29:12; Joahaz, "Yahweh has grasped." The eighteenth year, about 622 BC.
- g (34:9) Hilkiah, "my portion is Yahweh." The Ketiv reads "and they returned to Jerusalem," the Qere "and the inhabitants of Jerusalem."
- h (34:12) Jahath, perhaps "he will snatch up"; Obadiah, see 17:7; Merari, see 29:12; Zechariah, see 17:7; Meshullam, "repaid" or "allied."
- i (34:14) Hebrew "by the hand of Moses"; probably all or part of Deuteronomy.
- j (34:20) Ahikam, "my brother has arisen"; Abdon, "servant" (2 Kings 22:12 Achbor, "mouse"); Micah, short for Micaiah; Asaiah, "Yahweh has made."
- k (34:22) Huldah, "weasel" or "mole"; Shallum, see 28:12; Tokhath, meaning uncertain (the Ketiv spells it Tovqehath; 2 Kings 22:14 Tikvah, "hope"); Hasrah (2 Kings 22:14 Harhas). "The second quarter," Hebrew mishneh, a newer district of Jerusalem.
- l (34:25) The Ketiv and Qere differ in the form of the verb "burned incense."
- m (34:28) Josiah died in battle (35:23–24), but "in peace" may mean before the disaster fell on Jerusalem, and buried in his own tomb.

Chapter 35

1 And Josiah kept a passover to Yahweh in Jerusalem; and they killed
the passover on the fourteenth day of the first month (in March–
April).[a] 2 And he set the priests in their offices and encouraged them
to the service of the house of Yahweh. 3 And he said to the Levites
that taught all Israel, which were holy to Yahweh, "Put the holy ark
in the house which Solomon the son of David king of Israel built;
there shall no more be a burden upon your shoulders. Now serve
Yahweh your God and his people Israel.[b] 4 And prepare yourselves

after your fathers' houses by your courses, according to the writing of David king of Israel and according to the writing of Solomon his son. 5 And stand in the holy place according to the divisions of the fathers' houses of your brethren the children of the people, and let there be for each a portion of a fathers' house of the Levites. 6 And kill the passover, and sanctify yourselves, and prepare for your brethren, to do according to the word of Yahweh by the hand of Moses."
7 And Josiah gave to the children of the people, of the flock, lambs and kids, all for the passover offerings, to all that were present, to the number of thirty thousand, and three thousand bullocks; these were of the king's substance. 8 And his princes gave for a freewill offering to the people, to the priests, and to the Levites. Hilkiah and Zechariah and Jehiel, the rulers of the house of God, gave to the priests for the passover offerings two thousand and six hundred small cattle, and three hundred oxen.[c] 9 Conaniah also, and Shemaiah and Nethanel, his brethren, and Hashabiah and Jeiel and Jozabad, the chiefs of the Levites, gave to the Levites for the passover offerings five thousand small cattle, and five hundred oxen.[d]
10 So the service was prepared, and the priests stood in their place, and the Levites by their courses, according to the king's commandment. 11 And they killed the passover, and the priests sprinkled the blood which they received of their hand, and the Levites flayed them. 12 And they removed the burnt offerings, that they might give them according to the divisions of the fathers' houses of the children of the people, to offer to Yahweh, as it is written in the book of Moses. And so did they with the oxen. 13 And they roasted the passover with fire according to the ordinance; and the holy offerings they boiled in pots and in caldrons and in pans, and carried them quickly to all the children of the people.[e] 14 And afterward they prepared for themselves and for the priests, because the priests the sons of Aaron were busied in offering the burnt offerings and the fat until night; therefore the Levites prepared for themselves and for the priests the sons of Aaron.
15 And the singers the sons of Asaph were in their place, according to the commandment of David, and Asaph, and Heman, and Jeduthun the king's seer; and the porters were at every gate. They needed not

to depart from their service, for their brethren the Levites prepared for them.[f] 16 So all the service of Yahweh was prepared the same day, to keep the passover and to offer burnt offerings upon the altar of Yahweh, according to the commandment of King Josiah. 17 And the children of Israel that were present kept the passover at that time, and the feast of unleavened bread seven days. 18 And there was no passover like that kept in Israel from the days of Samuel the prophet; neither did any of the kings of Israel keep such a passover as Josiah kept, and the priests, and the Levites, and all Judah and Israel that were present, and the inhabitants of Jerusalem.[g] 19 In the eighteenth year of the reign of Josiah was this passover kept.[h]
20 After all this, when Josiah had prepared the house, Neco king of Egypt went up to fight against Carchemish by the Euphrates; and Josiah went out against him.[i] 21 But he sent messengers to him, saying, "What have I to do with you, you king of Judah? I come not against you this day, but against the house with which I have war; and God has commanded me to make haste. Forbear from meddling with God, who is with me, that he destroy you not." 22 Nevertheless Josiah would not turn his face from him, but disguised himself, that he might fight with him, and hearkened not to the words of Neco from the mouth of God, and came to fight in the valley of Megiddo.[j] 23 And the archers shot at King Josiah; and the king said to his servants, "Take me away, for I am sore wounded." 24 So his servants took him out of the chariot and put him in the second chariot that he had, and brought him to Jerusalem; and he died, and was buried in the sepulchres of his fathers. And all Judah and Jerusalem mourned for Josiah.[k] 25 And Jeremiah lamented for Josiah; and all the singing men and singing women spoke of Josiah in their lamentations unto this day; and they made them an ordinance in Israel. And behold, they are written in the lamentations.[l] 26 Now the rest of the acts of Josiah and his good deeds, according to that which is written in the law of Yahweh, 27 and his acts, first and last, behold, they are written in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah.

Notes

- a (35:1) Josiah, see 33:25. The first month, Nisan (Abib), counted from the spring new year. Compare 2 Kings 23:21–23, which gives three verses to what Chronicles describes in nineteen.
- b (35:3) The ark had apparently been removed, perhaps under Manasseh or Amon; the reason is not stated.
- c (35:8) Hilkiah, see 34:9; Zechariah, see 17:7; Jehiel, "God lives." "Small cattle," that is, sheep and goats.
- d (35:9) Conaniah, "Yahweh has established" (the Ketiv spells it Conaniahu); Shemaiah, see 11:2; Nethanel, "God has given"; Hashabiah, "Yahweh has reckoned"; Jeiel, "God has swept away" or "treasured"; Jozabad, "Yahweh has given." Compare 31:12–15.
- e (35:13) Hebrew "boiled (bishshelu) the passover in fire," here meaning "cooked"; compare Exodus 12:8–9, which forbids boiling, and Deuteronomy 16:7.
- f (35:15) Asaph, "he has gathered"; Heman, "faithful"; Jeduthun, perhaps "praising."
- g (35:18) Second Kings 23:22 reads "from the days of the judges."
- h (35:19) About 622 BC, the same year the book was found (34:8).
- i (35:20) Neco II, pharaoh about 610–595 BC. Carchemish, "fortress of Chemosh" (?), on the Euphrates in northern Syria. In 609 BC Neco marched to support the last Assyrian king against Babylon; 2 Kings 23:29 says he went up "against (or to) the king of Assyria." Euphrates, Hebrew Perath.
- j (35:22) Megiddo, a city guarding the pass into the Jezreel plain. Compare 1 Esdras 1:28, which presents Neco's words as from Jeremiah; the Septuagint reads "the plain of Megiddo."
- k (35:24) Second Kings 23:29–30 says he died at Megiddo and was carried dead to Jerusalem.
- l (35:25) Jeremiah, perhaps "Yahweh exalts" or "Yahweh founds." This collection of laments is not the canonical book of Lamentations, though later tradition linked them.

Chapter 36

1 Then the people of the land took Jehoahaz the son of Josiah and made
him king in his father's place in Jerusalem.[a] 2 Joahaz was twenty-
three years old when he began to reign; and he reigned three months
in Jerusalem.[b] 3 And the king of Egypt deposed him at Jerusalem,
and fined the land about three and three-quarter tons of silver and
seventy-five pounds of gold.[c] 4 And the king of Egypt made Eliakim
his brother king over Judah and Jerusalem, and changed his name
to Jehoiakim. And Neco took Joahaz his brother and carried him to
Egypt.[d]

5 Jehoiakim was twenty-five years old when he began to reign; and he
reigned eleven years in Jerusalem; and he did that which was evil in
the sight of Yahweh his God.[e] 6 Against him came up Nebuchadnezzar
king of Babylon, and bound him in fetters to carry him to Babylon.[f] 7
Nebuchadnezzar also carried of the vessels of the house of Yahweh to
Babylon and put them in his temple at Babylon. 8 Now the rest of the
acts of Jehoiakim, and his abominations which he did, and that which
was found in him, behold, they are written in the book of the kings
of Israel and Judah; and Jehoiachin his son reigned in his place.[g]
9 Jehoiachin was eight years old when he began to reign; and he
reigned three months and ten days in Jerusalem; and he did that
which was evil in the sight of Yahweh.[h] 10 And at the return of the
year King Nebuchadnezzar sent and brought him to Babylon, with
the goodly vessels of the house of Yahweh, and made Zedekiah his
brother king over Judah and Jerusalem.[i]
11 Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he began to reign; and he
reigned eleven years in Jerusalem.[j] 12 And he did that which was evil in
the sight of Yahweh his God; he humbled not himself before Jeremiah
the prophet speaking from the mouth of Yahweh. 13 And he also
rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar, who had made him swear by
God; but he stiffened his neck and hardened his heart against turning
to Yahweh, the God of Israel. 14 Moreover all the chiefs of the priests
and the people trespassed very greatly after all the abominations of
the nations; and they polluted the house of Yahweh which he had
hallowed in Jerusalem.
15 And Yahweh, the God of their fathers, sent to them by his messen-
gers, rising up early and sending, because he had compassion on his
people and on his dwelling place; 16 but they mocked the messengers
of God, and despised his words, and scoffed at his prophets, until the
wrath of Yahweh arose against his people, till there was no remedy.
17 Therefore he brought upon them the king of the Chaldeans, who
slew their young men with the sword in the house of their sanctuary,
and had no compassion upon young man or virgin, old man or hoary
head; he gave them all into his hand.[k] 18 And all the vessels of the house
of God, great and small, and the treasures of the house of Yahweh,

and the treasures of the king and of his princes, all these he brought to Babylon. 19 And they burned the house of God, and broke down the wall of Jerusalem, and burned all its palaces with fire, and destroyed all its goodly vessels.[l] 20 And those that had escaped from the sword he carried away to Babylon; and they were servants to him and his sons until the reign of the kingdom of Persia,[m] 21 to fulfil the word of Yahweh by the mouth of Jeremiah, until the land had enjoyed her sabbaths; for as long as she lay desolate she kept sabbath, to fulfil seventy years.[n]

22 Now in the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of Yahweh by the mouth of Jeremiah might be accomplished, Yahweh stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom, and put it also in writing, saying,[o]

23 "This is what Cyrus king of Persia says: Yahweh, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me with building him a house at Jerusalem in Judah. Whoever among you belongs to his people, may Yahweh your God be with him. Let him go up."[p]

Notes

- a (36:1) Jehoahaz, "Yahweh has grasped"; also called Shallum (1 Chronicles 3:15; Jeremiah 22:11). Verses 1–4 parallel 2 Kings 23:30–35, about 609 BC.
- b (36:2) Joahaz, a shorter form of Jehoahaz. Second Kings 23:31 adds that his mother was Hamutal of Libnah; the Septuagint adds the same here, with further material from Kings in verses 2–5.
- c (36:3) Hebrew "a hundred talents of silver and a talent of gold." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms); 100 talents ≈ 3.75 tons (3,400 kilograms).
- d (36:4) Eliakim, "God raises up"; Jehoiakim, "Yahweh raises up." Second Kings 23:34 says Joahaz died in Egypt.
- e (36:5) Compare 2 Kings 23:36–24:6, about 609–598 BC.
- f (36:6) Nebuchadnezzar, Akkadian Nabu-kudurri-usur, "Nabu, protect the heir," king of Babylon about 605–562 BC. Second Kings 24:6 says Jehoiakim "slept with his fathers," and does not mention his being taken to Babylon; compare Daniel 1:1–2. The Septuagint here adds material about his burial.
- g (36:8) Jehoiachin, "Yahweh establishes"; also called Jeconiah and Coniah (1 Chronicles 3:16; Jeremiah 22:24).
- h (36:9) Second Kings 24:8 reads "eighteen years old," which fits his having wives (2 Kings 24:15); "eight" here, also in the Septuagint, may be a copying error in which "ten" dropped out. "Ten days" is also not in Kings. In 597 BC.

- i (36:10) Zedekiah, "Yahweh is righteousness," originally named Mattaniah (2 Kings 24:17). Hebrew "brother" is used loosely for kinsman; 2 Kings 24:17 calls him Jehoiachin's uncle ("his father's brother," as the Septuagint reads here). First Chronicles 3:16 lists a Zedekiah as Jehoiachin's son or brother. "The return of the year," the spring.
- j (36:11) Compare 2 Kings 24:18–25:21; Jeremiah 52. Jerusalem fell in 587 or 586 BC.
- k (36:17) Chaldeans, the people of southern Mesopotamia who formed the Neo-Babylonian dynasty. The Ketiv spells the word with an extra letter.
- l (36:19) Second Kings 25:8–9 dates the burning to the seventh day of the fifth month (Ab, July–August); Jeremiah 52:12 the tenth day.
- m (36:20) Persia, Hebrew Paras. Babylon fell to Cyrus in 539 BC.
- n (36:21) Compare Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10; Leviticus 26:34–35, 43.
- o (36:22) Cyrus, Hebrew Koresh (Old Persian Kurush), Persian king about 559–530 BC; his first year over Babylon was 538 BC. Verses 22–23 are repeated, and continued, at Ezra 1:1–3.
- p (36:23) In the Hebrew canon Chronicles is usually the last book, so the Hebrew Bible ends on the summons to "go up."

Ezra

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the first year[a] of Cyrus[b] king of Persia, so that the word of Yahweh
spoken by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled,[c] Yahweh stirred
up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, and he had a proclamation made
throughout his whole kingdom, and also put it in writing: 2 "Thus says
Cyrus king of Persia: Yahweh, the God of heaven, has given me all the
kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me to build him a house
in Jerusalem, which is in Judah. 3 Whoever among you belongs to his
people, may his God be with you; let that person travel to Jerusalem
in Judah and rebuild the temple of Yahweh, Israel's God, who dwells
in Jerusalem. 4 And everyone who is left, in any place where he lives
as a foreigner, let the men of that place help him with silver and gold,
with goods and with livestock, besides the freewill offering for the
house of God that is in Jerusalem."
5 Then the heads of the fathers' houses of Judah and Benjamin rose
up, with the priests and the Levites, everyone whose spirit God had
stirred, to go up and build the house of Yahweh that is in Jerusalem.
6 All who were around them strengthened their hands with articles
of silver, with gold, with goods, with livestock, and with costly gifts,
besides all that was given as a freewill offering.
7 King Cyrus also released the vessels belonging to Yahweh's house
that Nebuchadnezzar[d] had taken from Jerusalem and stored in the
temple of his gods. 8 Cyrus king of Persia had them brought out
through Mithredath[e] the treasurer, who tallied them for Sheshbazzar,[f]
the leader of Judah. 9 And this was their number: 30 gold basins,[g]
1,000 silver basins, 29 knives,[h] 10 thirty gold bowls, four hundred ten
silver bowls of a second kind,[i] and a thousand other vessels. 11 All the
articles of gold and of silver were 5,400. Sheshbazzar brought all these
up when the exiles were brought up from Babylon to Jerusalem.[j]

Notes

- a (1:1) In the Hebrew Bible, Ezra and Nehemiah were counted as a single book, and the Masoretic notes treat them as one. In the Septuagint the two together form the book called Esdras B, or 2 Esdras (Ezra is chapters 1–10 and Nehemiah chapters 11–23); a different Greek book, Esdras A or 1 Esdras, retells 2 Chronicles 35–36, Ezra, and Nehemiah 7:73–8:12 and is placed with the Apocrypha in this translation. In the Latin Vulgate, Ezra is called 1 Esdras and Nehemiah 2 Esdras, while the Greek 1 Esdras is 3 Esdras. The first year of Cyrus as ruler of Babylon was 539–538 BC.
- b (1:1) Cyrus (Persian Kurush) is Cyrus II, "the Great," founder of the Persian Empire, who took Babylon in 539 BC. The meaning of the name is uncertain.
- c (1:1) See Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10. Verses 1–3a repeat 2 Chronicles 36:22–23.
- d (1:7) Nebuchadnezzar (Babylonian Nabû-kudurri-uṣur, "O Nabu, protect the heir") was king of Babylon 605–562 BC. He carried off the temple articles (2 Kings 24:13; 25:13–15). The written Hebrew text (ketiv) spells the name Nebuchadnezzor.
- e (1:8) Mithredath is a Persian name meaning "given by Mithra."
- f (1:8) Sheshbazzar is a Babylonian name, perhaps "O Shamash (or Sin), protect the father." Some identify him with Shenazzar (1 Chronicles 3:18) or with Zerubbabel (compare 3:8 and 5:16), but this is uncertain.
- g (1:9) The meaning of the Hebrew 'agarṭal is uncertain; perhaps a basin or large dish.
- h (1:9) The meaning of the Hebrew maḥalaphim is uncertain; perhaps knives, censers, or "replacement" vessels.
- i (1:10) Hebrew mishnim, perhaps "of second quality" or "matching"; the meaning is uncertain.
- j (1:11) The figures given in verses 9–10 add up to 2,499, not 5,400. Perhaps only the main items are listed, or some numbers were changed in copying. 1 Esdras (2:13–14) gives different figures and a total of 5,469.

Chapter 2

1 These are the people of the province who came back from captivity
in exile, whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had carried off to
Babylon. Each returned to Jerusalem and Judah, to their own town.[a]
2 They came with Zerubbabel,[b] Jeshua,[c] Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah,
Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah.[d] The number
of the men of the people of Israel: 3 the sons of Parosh, 2,172; 4 the
sons of Shephatiah, 372; 5 the sons of Arah, 775; 6 the sons of Pahath-
moab,[e] of the sons of Jeshua and Joab, 2,812; 7 the sons of Elam, 1,254;
8 the sons of Zattu, 945; 9 the sons of Zaccai, 760; 10 the sons of Bani,
642; 11 the sons of Bebai, 623; 12 the sons of Azgad, 1,222; 13 the sons of
Adonikam,[f] 666; 14 the sons of Bigvai, 2,056; 15 the sons of Adin, 454;

16 the sons of Ater, of Hezekiah, 98; 17 the sons of Bezai, 323; 18 the
sons of Jorah, 112; 19 the sons of Hashum, 223; 20 the sons of Gibbar,
95; 21 the men of Bethlehem, 123;[g] 22 the men of Netophah, 56; 23 the
men of Anathoth, 128; 24 the people of Azmaveth, 42; 25 the people of
Kiriath-arim,[h] Chephirah, and Beeroth, 743; 26 the people of Ramah
and Geba, 621; 27 the men of Michmas, 122; 28 the men of Bethel and
Ai, 223; 29 the people of Nebo, 52; 30 the people of Magbish, 156; 31 the
sons of the other Elam, 1,254; 32 the sons of Harim, 320; 33 the people
of Lod, Hadid, and Ono, 725; 34 the people of Jericho, 345; 35 the people
of Senaah, 3,630.
36 The priests: the sons of Jedaiah, of the house of Jeshua, 973; 37 the
sons of Immer, 1,052; 38 the sons of Pashhur, 1,247; 39 the sons of Harim,
1,017.
40 The Levites: the sons of Jeshua and Kadmiel, of the sons of
Hodaviah, 74.
41 The singers: the sons of Asaph, 128.
42 The sons of the gatekeepers: the sons of Shallum and Ater, Talmon
and Akkub, Hatita and Shobai, totaling 139.
43 The temple servants:[i] the sons of Ziha, of Hasupha, of Tabbaoth,
44 the sons of Keros, of Siaha, of Padon, 45 the sons of Lebanah, of
Hagabah, of Akkub, 46 the sons of Hagab, of Shalmai,[j] of Hanan, 47 the
sons of Giddel, of Gahar, of Reaiah, 48 the sons of Rezin, of Nekoda, of
Gazzam, 49 the sons of Uzza, of Paseah, of Besai, 50 the sons of Asnah, of
Meunim, of Nephusim,[k] 51 the sons of Bakbuk, of Hakupha, of Harhur,
52 the sons of Bazluth, of Mehida, of Harsha, 53 the sons of Barkos, of
Sisera, of Temah, 54 the sons of Neziah, and of Hatipha.
55 Of Solomon's servants:[l] the sons of Sotai, of Hassophereth, of
Peruda, 56 the sons of Jaalah, of Darkon, of Giddel, 57 the sons of Shephatiah, of Hattil, of Pochereth-hazzebaim, and of Ami. 58 The temple
servants together with the sons of Solomon's servants totaled 392.
59 And these went up from Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addan,
and Immer, but they were unable to show their fathers' house and
their lineage, whether they were of Israel: 60 the sons of Delaiah, of
Tobiah, and of Nekoda, 652. 61 And from the priestly families: the
descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai (the last had married

one of the daughters of Barzillai from Gilead and was called by that name).[m] 62 These searched for their entry among those enrolled in the genealogies, but it was not found, and so they were barred from the priesthood as unclean. 63 The governor[n] told them that they were not to eat any of the most holy food until a priest should arise to consult the Urim and Thummim.[o]

64 The whole assembly together was 42,360,[p] 65 besides their male and female servants, who were 7,337. They also had 200 singing men and singing women. 66 Their horses were 736, their mules 245, 67 their camels 435, and their donkeys 6,720.

68 When they came to the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem, some of the heads of the fathers' houses made freewill offerings for the house of God, to set it up on its site. 69 According to their means they gave to the treasury for the work 61,000 gold darics (about 1,130 pounds of gold),[q] about 3 tons of silver,[r] and 100 priests' garments. 70 So the priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns, and all Israel in their towns.

Notes

- a (2:1) The list in verses 1–70 is repeated, with many small differences in names and numbers, in Nehemiah 7:6–73 and in 1 Esdras 5:7–45.
- b (2:2) Zerubbabel probably means "offspring of Babylon" (Babylonian zēr-Bābili). He was a grandson of King Jehoiachin (1 Chronicles 3:17–19).
- c (2:2) Jeshua is a later form of Joshua, "Yahweh saves." He is the high priest called Joshua in Haggai 1:1 and Zechariah 3:1.
- d (2:2) This Nehemiah and this Mordecai are not the Nehemiah and Mordecai of the books of Nehemiah and Esther. Nehemiah 7:7 has twelve leaders, adding Nahamani, and reads Azariah for Seraiah, Raamiah for Reelaiah, Mispereth for Mispar, and Nehum for Rehum.
- e (2:6) Pahath-moab means "governor of Moab."
- f (2:13) Adonikam means "my lord has arisen."
- g (2:21) Hebrew "the sons of Bethlehem." In verses 21–35 "sons of" a town means its people.
- h (2:25) Kiriath-arim is probably the same as Kiriath-jearim, "town of forests" (Nehemiah 7:29).
- i (2:43) Hebrew netinim, "those given," that is, people given (dedicated) to serve in the temple (compare 8:20).
- j (2:46) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Shamlai.

- k (2:50) Meunim and Nephusim follow the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Meinim and Nephisim.
- l (2:55) Perhaps sons of foreigners conscripted for royal service by Solomon (1 Kings 9:20–21).
- m (2:61) See 2 Samuel 17:27; 19:31–39.
- n (2:63) Hebrew Tirshatha, a Persian title, perhaps "His Excellency." In Nehemiah 8:9; 10:1 it is the title of Nehemiah.
- o (2:63) The Urim and Thummim (perhaps "lights and perfections") were objects kept in the high priest's breastpiece and used to learn the will of God (Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21).
- p (2:64) The figures in verses 3–60 add up to 29,818 (Nehemiah 7 gives 31,089). The difference may include women, or groups not listed by family, or may come from errors in copying.
- q (2:69) Hebrew darkemonim, either the Persian gold daric or the Greek drachma. A daric weighed about 0.3 ounce (8.4 grams), so 61,000 darics weighed about 512 kilograms.
- r (2:69) Hebrew "5,000 minas of silver." A mina was about 1¼ pounds (575 grams), so 5,000 minas is about 6,250 pounds (2,875 kilograms).

Chapter 3

1 When the seventh month (in September–October)[a] came, with the
sons of Israel in the towns, the people assembled to Jerusalem like a
single man. 2 Then Jeshua son of Jozadak[b] and his fellow priests, along
with Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel[c] and his relatives, set about building
the altar of Israel's God, so they could present burnt offerings on it,
following the instructions written in the Law of Moses, God's servant.
3 They erected the altar on its old foundation, since they feared the
surrounding peoples, and they presented burnt offerings on it to
Yahweh, every morning and evening.[d] 4 They celebrated the Festival
of Booths[e] as prescribed, and presented the daily burnt offerings in
the numbers the regulation required for each day, 5 and after that the
regular burnt offering, the offerings for the new moons and for all the
consecrated appointed feasts of Yahweh, and the offerings of every-
one who brought a freewill offering to Yahweh. 6 From the first day
of the seventh month (September–October) they began presenting
burnt offerings to Yahweh, even though the temple's foundation had
not yet been laid. 7 They paid money to stonemasons and carpenters,
and supplied food, drink, and oil to the Sidonians and Tyrians so they

would ship cedar timber from Lebanon across the sea to Joppa, with the authorization Cyrus king of Persia had granted them.
8 In the second year after they came to the house of God at Jerusalem, in the second month (in April–May),[f] Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel and Jeshua son of Jozadak began, along with the remainder of their brothers, the priests and Levites and everyone who had come from the captivity to Jerusalem. They set the Levites twenty years old and upward to oversee the work on the house of Yahweh. 9 And Jeshua with his sons and his brothers, Kadmiel and his sons, the sons of Judah,[g] stood together to oversee those doing the work on the house of God, with the sons of Henadad, their sons and their brothers the Levites. 10 When the builders laid the temple's foundation, the priests, dressed in their robes, took their places with trumpets, and the Levites, Asaph's descendants, with cymbals, to praise Yahweh as King David of Israel had instructed. 11 And they sang to one another in praise and thanksgiving to Yahweh: "For he is good, for his steadfast love[h] toward Israel is forever." And all the people raised a great shout as they praised Yahweh, because the foundation of the house of Yahweh had been laid. 12 But many of the priests and Levites and heads of fathers' houses, the old men who had seen the first house, wept aloud when the foundation of this house was laid before their eyes, while many others shouted aloud for joy. 13 No one could tell the noise of the joyful shouting apart from the noise of the weeping among the people, for the people were shouting with a great shout, and the noise was heard from far away.

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew "the seventh month," Tishri, counted from the spring new year. Because the Hebrew months were lunar, it did not match a modern month exactly but fell in September–October. This was probably the autumn of 538 or 537 BC.
- b (3:2) Jozadak (also Jehozadak, 1 Chronicles 6:15) means "Yahweh is righteous."
- c (3:2) Shealtiel means "I have asked God." In 1 Chronicles 3:19 Zerubbabel is called a son of Pedaiah, Shealtiel's brother; he may have been a legal heir of Shealtiel.
- d (3:3) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "he offered."
- e (3:4) Hebrew sukkot, "booths" or "shelters," celebrated from the fifteenth to the twenty-first day of the seventh month (Leviticus 23:33–43).

- f (3:8) Hebrew "the second month," Iyyar (earlier called Ziv), which fell in April–May. Solomon also began his temple in the second month (1 Kings 6:1).
- g (3:9) "Judah" (Hebrew Yehudah) may stand for Hodaviah (Hebrew Hodawyah) of 2:40, a name that looks similar in Hebrew.
- h (3:11) Hebrew ḥesed, faithful, loyal love, especially love that keeps a covenant.

Chapter 4

1 When the adversaries of Judah and Benjamin heard that the returned
exiles[a] were building a temple for Yahweh, the God of Israel, 2 they
approached Zerubbabel and the family heads and told them, "Let us
join you in building, for we worship your God just as you do, and we
have offered sacrifices to him[b] ever since Esarhaddon[c] king of Assyria
settled us here." 3 But Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the rest of the heads
of the fathers' houses of Israel said to them, "It is not for you and us
together to build a house for our God. We alone will build for Yahweh,
the God of Israel, as King Cyrus, the king of Persia, commanded us." 4
Then the people of the land kept weakening the hands of the people
of Judah and frightening them[d] from building. 5 They hired counselors
against them to frustrate their plans all the days of Cyrus king of
Persia, until the reign of Darius[e] king of Persia.
6 When Ahasuerus[f] began his reign, they drafted a written charge
against the people living in Judah and Jerusalem. 7 In Artaxerxes'
time,[g] Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel,[h] and their other colleagues[i] wrote
to Artaxerxes king of Persia. The letter was written in Aramaic script
and rendered in Aramaic.[j] 8 Rehum the commander[k] and Shimshai
the scribe wrote a letter against Jerusalem to King Artaxerxes as
follows:[l] 9 Rehum the commander and Shimshai the scribe, with the
rest of their colleagues, the judges and the envoys, the officials, the
Persians,[m] the people of Erech,[n] of Babylon, and of Susa (that is, the
Elamites), 10 and the other peoples whom the great and illustrious
Osnappar[o] deported and settled in Samaria's cities and elsewhere in
the province west of the Euphrates.[p] And now 11 (this is a copy of the
letter that they sent to him): "To King Artaxerxes, from your servants,
the men of the province Beyond the River. And now 12 let it be known
to the king that the Jews who came up from you to us have come to
Jerusalem. They are rebuilding that rebellious and evil city.[q] They are

finishing the walls and repairing the foundations. 13 The king should
also know that if this city is rebuilt and its walls completed, they will
refuse to pay tribute, duty, or tolls, and eventually the royal treasury
will be diminished.[r] 14 Now, because we eat the salt of the palace[s] and it
is not proper for us to see the king dishonored, we have therefore sent
to inform the king, 15 so that someone may search the record book of
your predecessors. There you will find and discover that this city has
always been rebellious, damaging to kings and provinces, and that its
people have fomented uprisings since ancient times. For this reason
the city was destroyed. 16 We are informing the king that if this city
is built and its walls completed, you will have no share left on that
account in the province Beyond the River."
17 The king sent this reply: "To Rehum the commander, Shimshai the
secretary, and their other colleagues living in Samaria and the rest
of the province west of the Euphrates: Greetings. And now 18 the
letter that you sent us has been read before me word for word.[t] 19 I
issued a decree, and a search was made, and it was found that from
ancient days this city has risen up against kings, and that rebellion
and revolt have been carried on in it. 20 Powerful kings have ruled
over Jerusalem and governed the whole province Beyond the River,
and tribute, custom, and toll were paid to them. 21 Now issue a decree
that these men be made to stop, and that this city not be rebuilt until
a decree is issued by me. 22 Take care not to be negligent in acting on
this. Why should the damage grow to the hurt of the kings?"
23 Then, as soon as the copy of King Artaxerxes' letter was read before
Rehum and Shimshai the scribe and their associates, they hurried
to Jerusalem, to the Jews, and stopped them by force and power. 24
Then the work on the house of God in Jerusalem stopped. It remained
stopped until the second year of the reign of Darius king of Persia.[u]

Notes

- a (4:1) Literally "the sons of the exile."
- b (4:2) So the traditional reading (qere), lo, "to him." The written text (ketiv) has lo', "not": "and we have not been sacrificing." The Septuagint supports "to him."
- c (4:2) Esarhaddon (Assyrian Ashur-aḫa-iddina, "Ashur has given a brother") was king of Assyria 681–669 BC (2 Kings 19:37). On the peoples settled in Samaria by the Assyrian kings, see 2 Kings 17:24–41.

- d (4:4) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a rarer form of the same word.
- e (4:5) Darius I, king of Persia 522–486 BC. The name (Persian Darayavaush) probably means "he who holds firm the good."
- f (4:6) Ahasuerus (Hebrew 'Aḥashwerosh) is the Persian Khshayarsha, known in Greek as Xerxes, king of Persia 486–465 BC (see Esther 1:1). Verses 6–23 gather together later opposition under Xerxes and Artaxerxes, arranged by topic. The account of the temple building resumes in verse 24, in the time of Darius.
- g (4:7) Artaxerxes I, king of Persia 465–424 BC. The name (Persian Artakhshassa) means "whose reign is through truth."
- h (4:7) Bishlam may be a name or a phrase meaning "in peace" or "with the approval of." Mithredath means "given by Mithra." Tabeel is Aramaic, "God is good."
- i (4:7) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has the singular, "associate."
- j (4:7) Literally "written in Aramaic and translated; Aramaic." The last word probably marks the change of language: from verse 8 the book is written in Aramaic (see the note there).
- k (4:8) Aramaic be'el-ṭe'em, literally "lord of decree," an official title, perhaps "commissioner" or "chancellor."
- l (4:8) From here through 6:18 the original text is in Aramaic, not Hebrew. Aramaic, a language closely related to Hebrew, was the common language of government in the Persian Empire. Ezra 7:12–26 is also in Aramaic.
- m (4:9) The Aramaic terms dinaye, apharsathkaye, ṭarpelaye, and apharsaye are uncertain. Some may be titles of officials and some the names of peoples.
- n (4:9) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a different form of the same word. Erech is the ancient Uruk in Babylonia.
- o (4:10) Osnappar is probably Ashurbanipal, king of Assyria 668–627 BC.
- p (4:10) Aramaic 'abar-nahara, the Persian province west of the Euphrates River, which included Syria and the land of Israel.
- q (4:12) The traditional reading (qere) differs from the written text (ketiv) in the spelling of three words in this verse, without a change in meaning.
- r (4:13) The Aramaic word 'appethom is uncertain; it is probably a Persian loanword meaning "in the end" or "revenue."
- s (4:14) That is, we are in the king's service and under obligation to him.
- t (4:18) Aramaic mepharash, "distinctly," or "in translation."
- u (4:24) 520 BC (compare Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 1:1).

Chapter 5

1 Now the prophets, Haggai[a] the prophet and Zechariah[b] the son of
Iddo, prophesied to the Jews who were in Judah and Jerusalem, in the
name of the God of Israel who was over them. 2 Then Zerubbabel son

of Shealtiel and Jeshua son of Jozadak rose up and started to build the house of God in Jerusalem, and with them were the prophets of God, supporting them.

3 At that time Tattenai,[c] the governor of the province Beyond the River, and Shethar-bozenai[d] and their associates came to them and said to them, "Who gave you a decree to build this house and to complete this structure?"[e] 4 They also said to them,[f] "What are the names of the men who are constructing this building?" 5 But their God was watching over the Jewish elders, and the officials did not halt the work until a report could be sent to Darius and a written ruling returned.

6 This is a copy of the letter that Tattenai the governor of the province Beyond the River, Shethar-bozenai, and his associates the officials[g] in the province Beyond the River sent to Darius the king. 7 They sent him a report, in which this was written: "To Darius the king, all peace. 8 Let it be known to the king that we went to the province of Judah, to the great God's house. It is being built of huge stones,[h] with timber laid in the walls. This work is being carried on with diligence and is prospering in their hands. 9 Then we asked those elders and spoke to them this way: 'Who gave you a decree to build this house and to complete this structure?' 10 We also asked for their names, so that we could report to you and record the names of the men leading them. 11 And this is the reply they gave us: 'We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we are rebuilding the house that was built many years before, which a great king of Israel built and completed.[i] 12 But because our fathers provoked the God of heaven to anger, he gave them into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, the Chaldean,[j] who destroyed this house and carried the people away to Babylon. 13 However, in the first year of Cyrus king of Babylon, King Cyrus issued a decree that this house of God be rebuilt. 14 Also the vessels of gold and silver belonging to the house of God, which Nebuchadnezzar had removed from the temple at Jerusalem and carried into the temple of Babylon, King Cyrus took out of the temple of Babylon, and they were handed over to a man named Sheshbazzar, whom he had appointed governor. 15 He said to

him, “Take these articles. Go and put them in the temple in Jerusalem, and let the house of God be rebuilt on its site.” 16 So this Sheshbazzar came and set the foundations of God’s house in Jerusalem; and from then until now it has been in building and is not yet complete.’ 17 Now, if it seems good to the king, let a search be made in the royal treasure house there in Babylon, whether it is so that a decree was made by King Cyrus for building this house of God at Jerusalem. And let the king send us his decision about this.”

Notes

- a (5:1) Haggai means “festive,” perhaps because he was born on a feast day.
- b (5:1) Zechariah means “Yahweh remembers.” In Zechariah 1:1 he is the son of Berechiah, son of Iddo; here “son” means descendant.
- c (5:3) A Babylonian document from the reign of Darius names Tattannu as governor of Beyond the River, probably the same man.
- d (5:3) Shethar-bozenai is a Persian name of uncertain meaning.
- e (5:3) The Aramaic ’ushsharna is uncertain; perhaps the timberwork, the furnishings, or the whole structure. Also in verse 9.
- f (5:4) So the Septuagint. The Aramaic has “Then we told them,” which may be an early change of person in copying.
- g (5:6) The Aramaic apharsekaye is uncertain; perhaps “inspectors” or “officials.”
- h (5:8) Literally “stones of rolling,” stones so large that they had to be rolled into place.
- i (5:11) Solomon (1 Kings 6).
- j (5:12) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a different spelling.

Chapter 6

1 Then King Darius issued an order, and a search was conducted in Babylon, in the archive house,[a] where the treasures were kept. 2 And at Ecbatana,[b] the citadel in the province of Media, there was found a scroll, and in it was written: “A record: 3 In King Cyrus’s first year, Cyrus the king made a decree about the house of God in Jerusalem: Let the house be rebuilt as a place where sacrifices are offered, and let its foundations be retained.[c] Its height is to be about 90 feet and its width about 90 feet,[d] 4 with three courses of huge stones and one course of timber.[e] The expense is to be given from the king’s house.[f] 5 Also the vessels of gold and silver of God’s house, which Nebuchadnezzar removed from the temple at Jerusalem and carried to Babylon,

are to be given back and taken back to the temple at Jerusalem, every one to its own place. You are to put them in the house of God."
6 "Now then, Tattenai, governor of the province west of the Euphrates, Shethar-bozenai, and your fellow officials of that province, stay away from that site. 7 Let the work on this house of God alone. Let the governor of the Jews and the elders of the Jews rebuild this house of God on its site. 8 And I make a decree regarding what you shall do with these elders of the Jews toward the building of this house of God: from the king's goods the expense shall be paid to these men exactly and without delay, namely from the tribute of the province Beyond the River, so that they are not hindered. 9 Whatever is needed, whether young bulls, rams, or lambs as burnt offerings for the God of heaven, or wheat, salt, wine, or oil, according to what the priests in Jerusalem ask for, must be handed over to them each day without delay, 10 so that they may offer sacrifices of pleasing aroma to the God of heaven and pray for the life of the king and his sons. 11 I further decree that if anyone alters this edict, a beam is to be torn from his house and he is to be hoisted up and fixed to it,[g] and his house is to be reduced to a heap of ruins for this offense. 12 May the God who has caused his name to dwell there overthrow any king or people that puts out a hand to change this or to destroy this house of God in Jerusalem. I, Darius, issue the decree. Let it be carried out with all diligence."
13 Then Tattenai, the governor of the province Beyond the River, Shethar-bozenai, and their associates acted with all diligence according to what Darius the king had sent. 14 And the elders of the Jews built and prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet and Zechariah the son of Iddo. They finished their building by the command of the God of Israel and by the decree of Cyrus, Darius, and Artaxerxes king of Persia.[h] 15 This house was completed on the third day of the month Adar (February–March),[i] in the sixth year of the reign of Darius the king. 16 The people of Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the other returnees celebrated the dedication of this house of God with joy. 17 For the dedication of this house of God they presented a hundred bulls, two hundred rams, four hundred lambs,

and twelve male goats as a purification offering[j] on behalf of all Israel,
one for each of Israel's tribes. 18 They also stationed the priests by
their divisions and the Levites by their groups for God's service in
Jerusalem, following what is written in the book of Moses.[k]
19 On the fourteenth day of the first month (in March–April),[l] the
returned exiles kept the Passover. 20 For the priests and the Levites
had purified themselves as one; every one of them was clean. And
they killed the Passover for all the sons of the exile, for their brothers
the priests, and for themselves. 21 The Israelites who had come back
from exile ate it, along with all who had joined them, having separated themselves from the impurity of the surrounding peoples to
seek Yahweh, Israel's God. 22 And they kept the Feast of Unleavened
Bread seven days with joy, for Yahweh had made them joyful and
had turned the heart of the king of Assyria[m] toward them, so that he
strengthened their hands in the work on the house of God, the God
of Israel.

Notes

- a (6:1) Literally "the house of the books."
- b (6:2) Aramaic 'Aḥmetha, Ecbatana (modern Hamadan in Iran), a summer residence of the Persian kings.
- c (6:3) The meaning of the Aramaic mesobelin is uncertain; perhaps "retained," "raised," or "laid."
- d (6:3) Aramaic "sixty cubits … sixty cubits," about 27 meters. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 centimeters). The length is not given. Solomon's temple was 30 cubits high and 20 wide (1 Kings 6:2).
- e (6:4) So the Septuagint. The Aramaic has "a layer of new timber."
- f (6:4) Literally "from the house of the king."
- g (6:11) Or "fastened to it." The exact form of punishment is uncertain.
- h (6:14) Artaxerxes did not reign until after the temple was completed. He is probably named because he later supported the temple (7:15–24, 27).
- i (6:15) Aramaic "the month of Adar," the twelfth month of the spring-start calendar, a Babylonian month name used by the Jews after the exile. Because the months were lunar, Adar fell in February–March; the sixth year of Darius ended in early 515 BC, so the date was probably in March 515 BC. 1 Esdras 7:5 has "the twenty-third day."
- j (6:17) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a different spelling of the same word.

- k (6:18) The Aramaic section that began at 4:8 ends here. From verse 19 the text is again in Hebrew.
- l (6:19) Hebrew "the first month," called Nisan after the exile (Nehemiah 2:1; Esther 3:7). Because the Hebrew months were lunar, it fell in March–April. This was the spring of 515 BC.
- m (6:22) That is, the Persian king Darius, who now ruled the lands of the old Assyrian Empire.

Chapter 7

1 After these things, in the reign of Artaxerxes king of Persia, Ezra[a]
son of Seraiah, son of Azariah, son of Hilkiah, 2 son of Shallum, son
of Zadok, son of Ahitub, 3 son of Amariah, son of Azariah, son of
Meraioth, 4 son of Zerahiah, son of Uzzi, son of Bukki, 5 son of Abishua,
son of Phinehas, son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the chief priest.[b] 6
This Ezra went up from Babylon. He was a scribe skilled in the Law
of Moses, which Yahweh the God of Israel had given, and the king
granted him all he asked, because the hand of Yahweh his God was on
him. 7 There went up also some of the sons of Israel, and of the priests,
the Levites, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants, to
Jerusalem in the seventh year of Artaxerxes the king. 8 Ezra came
to Jerusalem in the fifth month (in July–August),[c] which was in the
seventh year of the king. 9 He had set out from Babylon on the first
day of the first month (March–April),[d] and reached Jerusalem on the
first day of the fifth month, since his God's gracious hand rested on
him. 10 For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of Yahweh and to
do it, and to teach statutes and judgments in Israel.
11 This is a copy of the letter that King Artaxerxes gave to Ezra the
priest, the scribe, a scholar in the words of the commandments of
Yahweh and his statutes for Israel: 12 "Artaxerxes, king of kings,[e] to
Ezra the priest, the scribe of the Law of the God of heaven: Peace in
full.[f] And now 13 A decree is made by me that anyone in my kingdom
of the people of Israel and its priests and Levites who offers himself
freely to go to Jerusalem may go with you. 14 For you are sent by the
king and his seven counselors to inquire about Judah and Jerusalem
according to the Law of your God, which is in your hand, 15 and to
carry the silver and gold that the king and his counselors have freely

offered to the God of Israel, whose dwelling is in Jerusalem, [16] along with all the silver and gold you may collect throughout Babylon's province, and the voluntary gifts from the people and priests, given willingly for their God's house in Jerusalem. [17] With this money, therefore, you are to be careful to buy bulls, rams, and lambs, with their grain offerings and their drink offerings, and you are to offer them on the altar of the house of your God in Jerusalem. [18] As for the remaining silver and gold, you and your colleagues[g] may use it however you judge best, in line with your God's will. [19] The articles that have been given to you for the service of the house of your God, deliver them in full before the God of Jerusalem. [20] And whatever else is needed for the house of your God that falls to you to provide, you may provide it from the king's treasure house. [21] And I, Artaxerxes the king, make a decree to all the treasurers who are Beyond the River: whatever Ezra the priest, the scribe of the Law of the God of heaven, asks of you, let it be done with all diligence, [22] up to about 3¾ tons of silver, about 600 bushels of wheat, about 580 gallons of wine, and about 580 gallons of olive oil,[h] and salt without limit. [23] Whatever is commanded by the God of heaven, let it be done exactly for the house of the God of heaven, so that wrath does not come against the realm of the king and his sons. [24] We also inform you that it is not permitted to impose tribute, custom, or toll on any of the priests, the Levites, the singers, the gatekeepers, the temple servants, or other servants of this house of God. [25] And you, Ezra, using the wisdom your God has placed in your hand, appoint administrators and judges to govern all the people of the province west of the Euphrates, everyone who knows your God's laws. Whoever does not know them, you must teach. [26] Anyone who will not obey the law of your God and the law of the king, let judgment be carried out on him strictly, whether death, banishment,[i] confiscation of property, or imprisonment."[j]

[27] Blessed be Yahweh, our ancestors' God, who inspired the king to do such a thing, to glorify Yahweh's house in Jerusalem, [28] and who showed me faithful kindness in the presence of the king, his advisers, and all his mighty officers. I took courage because Yahweh my God's hand was on me, and I assembled Israel's leaders to travel with me.[k]

Notes

- a (7:1) Ezra means "help," probably short for Azariah, "Yahweh has helped." If this Artaxerxes is Artaxerxes I, Ezra came to Jerusalem in 458 BC (verse 7). Some scholars think the king is Artaxerxes II, which would place Ezra's arrival in 398 BC.
- b (7:5) The genealogy is shortened; compare 1 Chronicles 6:3–15, which lists more generations between Meraioth and Azariah.
- c (7:8) Hebrew "the fifth month," Av, which fell in July–August.
- d (7:9) Hebrew "the first month," Nisan. The journey of about 900 miles (1,450 kilometers) took four months.
- e (7:12) From here through verse 26 the original text is in Aramaic (see the note at 4:8). "King of kings" was a title of the Persian kings.
- f (7:12) The Aramaic gemir, "complete," is uncertain here; it may belong to the title ("the perfect scribe") or to the greeting.
- g (7:18) In this verse the traditional reading (qere) has the Aramaic forms of "you" and "your brothers"; the written text (ketiv) has Hebrew-like spellings.
- h (7:22) Aramaic "100 talents of silver, 100 cors of wheat, 100 baths of wine, and 100 baths of oil." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so 100 talents was about 3,400 kilograms; a cor (the same as a homer) was about 6 bushels (220 liters); a bath (the liquid measure equal to an ephah) was about 5.8 gallons (22 liters). Measures varied in different times and places.
- i (7:26) So the traditional reading (qere), sheroshi, literally "rooting out," probably banishment; some take it as flogging. The written text (ketiv) has a different spelling.
- j (7:26) The Aramaic section that began at verse 12 ends here. From verse 27 the text is again in Hebrew.
- k (7:28) From 7:27 through 9:15 Ezra speaks in the first person.

Chapter 8

1 These are the heads of their fathers' houses, and this is the genealogy
of those who went up with me from Babylon in the reign of King Ar-
taxerxes: 2 Of the sons of Phinehas, Gershom. Of the sons of Ithamar,
Daniel. Of the sons of David, Hattush, 3 of the sons of Shecaniah.[a]
Of the sons of Parosh, Zechariah, and with him were registered 150
males. 4 Of the sons of Pahath-moab, Eliehoenai son of Zerahiah, and
with him 200 males. 5 Of the sons of Zattu,[b] Shecaniah son of Jahaziel,
and with him 300 males. 6 Of the sons of Adin, Ebed son of Jonathan,
and with him 50 males. 7 Of the sons of Elam, Jeshaiah son of Athaliah,
and with him 70 males. 8 Of the sons of Shephatiah, Zebadiah son of
Michael, and with him 80 males. 9 Of the sons of Joab, Obadiah son
of Jehiel, and with him 218 males. 10 Of the sons of Bani,[c] Shelomith

son of Josiphiah, and with him 160 males. 11 Of the sons of Bebai, Zechariah son of Bebai, and with him 28 males. 12 Of the sons of Azgad, Johanan son of Hakkatan, and with him 110 males. 13 Of the sons of Adonikam, those who came last; these are their names: Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah, and with them 60 males. 14 From the descendants of Bigvai: Uthai and Zaccur,[d] and seventy men with them.

15 I gathered them at the river that runs to Ahava,[e] and there we camped three days. When I reviewed the people and the priests, I found none of the sons of Levi there. 16 Then I sent for Eliezer, for Ariel, for Shemaiah, for Elnathan, for Jarib, for Elnathan, for Nathan, for Zechariah, and for Meshullam, heads, and for Joiarib and for Elnathan, men of understanding, 17 and I sent them[f] to Iddo, the leader at the place called Casiphia, and told them what to say to Iddo and his brothers[g] the temple servants at the place Casiphia, so that they would bring us ministers for the house of our God. 18 Because our God's gracious hand was upon us, they brought us a discerning man from the descendants of Mahli, who was Levi's son and Israel's grandson, Sherebiah[h] by name, together with his sons and brothers, eighteen in all; 19 and Hashabiah, together with Jeshaiah from Merari's descendants, with his relatives and their sons, twenty in all; 20 and of the temple servants, whom David and the officials had given to serve the Levites, 220 temple servants. All of them were designated by name.

21 There by the Ahava canal I proclaimed a fast, in order to humble ourselves in front of our God and ask him for a safe trip[i] for us, our children, and all our belongings. 22 I was embarrassed to request soldiers and cavalry from the king to shield us from enemies along the road, since we had told the king, "Our God's hand is good to everyone who seeks him, but his might and wrath are against all who abandon him." 23 So we fasted and asked our God about this, and he heard our prayer.

24 And I separated twelve of the chiefs of the priests, along with[j] Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and ten of their brothers with them. 25 Then I weighed out for them the silver, the gold, and the vessels, the contribution for our God's house that the king, his advisers, his officials,

and all the Israelites present had given.[k] 26 I weighed out into their
hands about 24 tons of silver, silver articles weighing about 3¾ tons,
about 3¾ tons of gold,[l] 27 20 gold bowls worth 1,000 darics (about 18½
pounds of gold),[m] and two articles of fine polished bronze, as precious
as gold. 28 And I said to them, "You are holy to Yahweh, and the articles
are holy, and the silver and the gold are a freewill offering to Yahweh,
the God of your fathers. 29 Guard them carefully until you weigh them
out in Jerusalem, in the storerooms of Yahweh's house, in front of
the chief priests, the Levites, and the family heads of Israel." 30 So the
priests and the Levites took over the weighed silver and gold and the
articles, to bring them to Jerusalem, to the house of our God.
31 Then we set out from the river Ahava on the twelfth day of the first
month (in March–April)[n] to go to Jerusalem. The hand of our God
was on us, and he rescued us from the hand of the enemy and from
those lying in ambush along the road. 32 We came to Jerusalem and
stayed there three days. 33 On the fourth day, in our God's house, the
silver, gold, and vessels were weighed and handed to Meremoth son
of Uriah the priest. Eleazar son of Phinehas was with him, along with
the Levites Jozabad son of Jeshua and Noadiah son of Binnui. 34 All
of it was by number and by weight, and all the weight was written
down at that time.
35 Then the exiles who had returned from captivity presented burnt
offerings to Israel's God: twelve bulls for all Israel, ninety-six rams,
seventy-seven lambs, and twelve male goats as a purification offering.
All of it was a burnt offering to Yahweh. 36 They also delivered
the king's orders to the king's satraps[o] and to the governors of the
province Beyond the River, and these supported the people and the
house of God.

Notes

- a (8:3) Hattush was a descendant of Shecaniah (1 Chronicles 3:22). The verse division between verses 2 and 3 is uncertain; Shecaniah may also begin a new entry.
- b (8:5) "Zattu" is not in the Hebrew but is found in the Septuagint and 1 Esdras 8:32. The Hebrew has "Of the sons of Shecaniah, the son of Jahaziel."
- c (8:10) "Bani" is not in the Hebrew but is found in the Septuagint. The Hebrew has "Of the sons of Shelomith, the son of Josiphiah."

- d (8:14) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Zabbud.
- e (8:15) The place Ahava and its canal in Babylonia have not been identified.
- f (8:17) So the traditional reading (qere), "I commanded them"; the written text (ketiv) has "I sent them out."
- g (8:17) Hebrew "his brother, the temple servants" (with the traditional reading, qere, netinim). Some read "his brothers and the temple servants."
- h (8:18) Hebrew "and Sherebiah." Some take the Hebrew 'ish sekel, "a man of insight," as a name, Ish-sechel.
- i (8:21) Literally "a straight way."
- j (8:24) Hebrew "to Sherebiah." Sherebiah and Hashabiah were Levites (verses 18–19), so the preposition is probably "in addition to." 1 Esdras 8:54 reads "and."
- k (8:25) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a longer form of the same verb.
- l (8:26) Hebrew "650 talents of silver, silver articles of 100 talents, 100 talents of gold." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so 650 talents is about 48,750 pounds (22,100 kilograms), and 100 talents about 7,500 pounds (3,400 kilograms). The Hebrew may also mean "100 silver articles worth … talents," with a number missing.
- m (8:27) Hebrew "1,000 'adarkonim," Persian gold darics. A daric weighed about 0.3 ounce (8.4 grams), so 1,000 darics weighed about 8.4 kilograms.
- n (8:31) Hebrew "the first month," Nisan. Compare 7:9: the start of the journey from Babylon had been set for the first day of the month.
- o (8:36) Hebrew 'aḥashdarpenim, from the Persian title for the rulers of the great provinces of the empire.

Chapter 9

1 After these things had been done, the officials came to me and said,
"The people of Israel, the priests, and the Levites have not separated
themselves from the peoples of the lands and their abominations,
from the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Jebusites, the
Ammonites, the Moabites, the Egyptians, and the Amorites. 2 They
have taken some of their daughters as wives for themselves and their
sons, so the holy line[a] has blended with the surrounding peoples.
And in this faithlessness the officials and leaders have taken the
lead."[b] 3 When I heard this, I tore my garment and my robe, pulled
out hair from my head and beard, and sat down appalled. 4 Then
everyone who trembled at the words of the God of Israel because of
the unfaithfulness of the returned exiles assembled to me, and I sat
appalled until the evening offering.[c] 5 And at the evening offering I

rose from my humbling of myself,[d] with my garment and my robe
torn, and I fell on my knees and spread out my hands to Yahweh my
God, 6 and prayed, "My God, I am so ashamed and embarrassed that I
cannot lift my face toward you, my God, because our wrongdoing has
risen higher than our heads, and our guilt has grown as high as the
heavens. 7 From the days of our fathers to this day we have been deep
in guilt. Because of our iniquities we, our kings, and our priests have
been handed over to the kings of the lands, to the sword, to captivity,
to plunder, and to open shame,[e] as it is today. 8 But now, for a brief
moment, Yahweh our God has been gracious, leaving us a surviving
remnant and giving us a firm place[f] in his holy site, so that he might
make our eyes shine and give us a small revival in our servitude. 9 We
are slaves. Yet our God has not abandoned us in our bondage, but has
shown us faithful kindness before the Persian kings, giving us relief
so that we could rebuild our God's house and repair its ruins, and
giving us a protective wall[g] in Judah and Jerusalem.
10 "And now, our God, what can we say after this? For we have
forsaken your commandments, 11 which you commanded by your ser-
vants the prophets, saying, 'The land that you are going in to possess
is a land made unclean by the impurity of the peoples of the lands, by
their abominations, with which they have filled it from one end to the
other with their uncleanness. 12 So now do not give your daughters
in marriage to their sons, and do not accept their daughters for your
sons, and never seek their peace or prosperity, so that you may be
strong, enjoy the land's good things, and leave it to your children
as an inheritance forever.'[h] 13 And after all that has come upon us for
our evil deeds and for our great guilt, since you, our God, have held
back punishment less than our iniquities deserved[i] and have given us
a remnant such as this, 14 shall we again break your commandments
and make marriages with the peoples of these abominations? Would
you not be angry with us until you had consumed us, so that there
would be no remnant and no one to escape? 15 O Yahweh, God of
Israel, you are righteous, for we remain a remnant that has escaped,
as it is today. Here we are before you in our guilt, though because of
it no one can stand before you."

Notes

- a (9:2) Literally "the holy seed" (compare Isaiah 6:13).
- b (9:2) Literally "the hand of the officials and the leaders has been first."
- c (9:4) The evening offering was the grain offering (minḥah) made in the late afternoon. In later Jewish practice it was offered at about three in the afternoon (compare Acts 3:1).
- d (9:5) Or "from my fasting."
- e (9:7) Literally "to shame of face."
- f (9:8) Literally "a tent peg," a fixed and secure place.
- g (9:9) Hebrew gader, a stone wall or fence, here probably a picture of protection.
- h (9:12) Compare Deuteronomy 7:1–3; 23:6.
- i (9:13) Literally "have restrained (or reckoned) below our iniquities."

Chapter 10

1 While Ezra was praying and making confession, weeping and
casting himself down before the house of God, there gathered to him
out of Israel an exceedingly great assembly of men and women and
children, and the people wept bitterly. 2 Then Shecaniah son of Jehiel,
of the sons of Elam,[a] answered and said to Ezra, "We have acted
unfaithfully toward our God and have taken foreign wives from the
peoples of the land. Yet even now there is hope for Israel in spite of
this. 3 Now then, let us cut a covenant with our God to put away all the
wives and those born of them, according to the counsel of my lord[b]
and of those who tremble at the commandment of our God, and let it
be done according to the Law. 4 Get up, for this is your responsibility,
and we are with you. Be strong and act." 5 Then Ezra got up and made
the leading priests, the Levites, and all Israel swear that they would
act according to this word. So they swore.
6 Then Ezra left the place before the house of God and went to the
chamber of Jehohanan son of Eliashib. He went there[c] without eating
bread or drinking water, for he was mourning over the unfaithfulness
of the exiles. 7 A proclamation went out across Judah and Jerusalem
to all the returned exiles to gather in Jerusalem, 8 and that if anyone
did not come within three days, according to the decision of the
officials and the elders, all his property would be forfeited[d] and he
himself would be separated from the assembly of the exiles. 9 Within
three days every man of Judah and Benjamin had come together

at Jerusalem, on the twentieth day of the ninth month (November–December).[e] All the people sat in the square before God's house, shaking over this matter and because of the downpour. 10 And Ezra the priest rose and said to them, "You have been unfaithful and have married foreign women, adding to the guilt of Israel. 11 Now therefore make confession to Yahweh, the God of your fathers, and do his will. Separate yourselves from the peoples of the land and from the foreign women." 12 Then all the assembly answered with a loud voice, "It is so. As you have said, so we must do.[f] 13 But the crowd is large, and rain is falling in this season. We are unable to stay outside. Nor can this be settled in a day or two, for we have sinned greatly in this affair. 14 Let our officials represent the entire assembly, and let everyone in our towns who has married a foreign woman come at appointed times, together with each town's elders and judges, until our God's fierce wrath over this matter is averted from us." 15 Only Jonathan son of Asahel and Jahzeiah son of Tikvah opposed this,[g] supported by Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite. 16 The returned exiles followed through. Ezra the priest chose family heads[h] by clan, each identified by name. On the first day of the tenth month (December–January)[i] they convened to investigate the matter, 17 and by the first day of the first month (in March–April)[j] they had finished dealing with all the men who had married foreign women.

18 Among the sons of the priests who had married foreign women were found these: of the sons of Jeshua son of Jozadak and his brothers, Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah. 19 They pledged themselves[k] to send away their wives, and being guilty they offered a ram of the flock for their guilt. 20 Of the sons of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah. 21 Of the sons of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah. 22 Of the sons of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah. 23 And of the Levites: Jozabad and Shimei and Kelaiah (he is Kelita), Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer. 24 Of the singers: Eliashib. Of the gatekeepers: Shallum, Telem, and Uri.

25 And of Israel: of the sons of Parosh, Ramiah, Izziah, Malchijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Malchijah,[l] and Benaiah. 26 Of the sons of Elam: Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi, Jeremoth, and Elijah. 27 Of the sons

of Zattu: Elioenai, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza.
28 Of the sons of Bebai: Jehohanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai. 29
Of the sons of Bani: Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal, and
Jeremoth.[m] 30 Of the sons of Pahath-moab: Adna, Chelal, Benaiah,
Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh. 31 Of the sons of
Harim: Eliezer, Isshijah, Malchijah, Shemaiah, Shimeon, 32 Benjamin,
Malluch, and Shemariah. 33 Of the sons of Hashum: Mattenai, Mattat-
tah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Manasseh, and Shimei. 34 Of the sons of
Bani: Maadai, Amram, Uel, 35 Benaiah, Bedeiah, Cheluhu,[n] 36 Vaniah,
Meremoth, Eliashib, 37 Mattaniah, Mattenai, Jaasai,[o] 38 Bani, Binnui,[p]
Shimei, 39 Shelemiah, Nathan, and Adaiah, 40 Machnadebai, Shashai,
Sharai, 41 Azarel, Shelemiah, and Shemariah, 42 Shallum, Amariah,
and Joseph. 43 Of the sons of Nebo: Jeiel, Mattithiah, Zabad, Zebina,
Jaddai,[q] Joel, and Benaiah. 44 All these had married foreign women,[r]
and some of them had wives by whom they had children.[s]

Notes

- a (10:2) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has ʿolam, "forever," a scribal slip.
- b (10:3) Hebrew ʾadonai, probably "my lord," addressing Ezra. With different vowels the same letters read Adonai, "the Lord."
- c (10:6) Some interpreters, following 1 Esdras 9:2, read "he spent the night there," a small change in the Hebrew.
- d (10:8) Hebrew yoḥoram, "devoted," placed under a ban, so that it was taken from its owner and given over to God.
- e (10:9) Hebrew "the ninth month," Kislev, which fell in November–December, the season of the winter rains.
- f (10:12) So the traditional reading (qere), "your word"; the written text (ketiv) has the plural, "your words."
- g (10:15) Some take the phrase to mean "were appointed over this" rather than "stood against this."
- h (10:16) So the Hebrew, literally "And there were set apart Ezra the priest, men, heads…." 1 Esdras 9:16 and the Syriac, reading a slightly different Hebrew, have "Ezra the priest selected men…."
- i (10:16) Hebrew "the tenth month," Tevet, which fell in December–January.
- j (10:17) Hebrew "the first month," Nisan, of the following year.
- k (10:19) Literally "they gave their hand."
- l (10:25) The Septuagint has Hashabiah for this second Malchijah.
- m (10:29) So the written text (ketiv); the traditional reading (qere) has "and Ramoth."

- n (10:35) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Cheluhi.
- o (10:37) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "and they did."
- p (10:38) The Hebrew reads "and Bani and Binnui"; the Septuagint has "and the sons of Banui and the sons of Semei." Many interpreters read "Of the sons of Binnui: Shimei."
- q (10:43) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Jaddau.
- r (10:44) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a different form of the verb.
- s (10:44) The Hebrew of this sentence is difficult: literally "and there were among them women, and they had set sons." 1 Esdras 9:36 reads "and they sent them away with their children."

Nehemiah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The words of Nehemiah[a] son of Hacaliah. In the month of Chislev
(November–December),[b] in the twentieth year,[c] I was in Susa the
citadel.[d] 2 Hanani, one of my brothers, came with some men from
Judah, and I asked them about the Jews who had escaped, those who
had survived the captivity, and about Jerusalem. 3 And they said to
me, "The survivors who remained from the captivity there in the
province are in great trouble and disgrace. The wall of Jerusalem is
broken through, and its gates have been burned with fire."
4 When I heard these words, I sat down and wept, and I mourned for
days, and I kept fasting and praying before the God of heaven. 5 I said,
"Yahweh, God of heaven, great and awesome God, you keep your
covenant and show faithful love to those who love you and obey your
commands. 6 Please look at me and listen to the prayer your servant
is praying to you today, day and night, for your servants the people
of Israel. I confess the sins we Israelites have committed against you.
Both I and my family have sinned. 7 We have dealt very corruptly with
you; we have not kept the commandments, the statutes, or the ordi-
nances that you gave to your servant Moses. 8 Remember, please, the
word that you commanded Moses your servant: 'If you act unfaith-
fully, I will scatter you among the peoples; 9 but if you turn back to
me and obey my commands, then even if your scattered people are
at the farthest reaches of the sky, I will gather them from there and
bring them[e] to the place I have chosen as a dwelling for my name.'[f]
10 They are your servants and your people, whom you redeemed by
your great power and by your strong hand. 11 Lord,[g] please listen to the
prayer of your servant and to the prayer of all your servants who take
joy in revering your name. Give your servant success today, and make
this man show him mercy." At that time I was the king's cupbearer.[h]

Notes

- a (1:1) Nehemiah means "Yahweh comforts." In the Hebrew Bible, Ezra and Nehemiah were counted as one book. In the Septuagint they form a single book, Esdras B (2 Esdras), of which Nehemiah is chapters 11–23; in the Latin Vulgate, Nehemiah is called 2 Esdras (and sometimes the Second Book of Ezra), while Ezra is 1 Esdras.
- b (1:1) Hebrew Kislev, the ninth month, which fell in November–December. The written text (ketiv) spells it Kislo.
- c (1:1) The twentieth year of Artaxerxes I (2:1), that is, late 446 BC.
- d (1:1) Susa (Hebrew Shushan), the winter capital of the Persian kings, in south-western Iran. The "citadel" (birah) was the fortified royal quarter.
- e (1:9) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a variant spelling of the same verb.
- f (1:9) See Leviticus 26:33; Deuteronomy 4:27; 12:5; 30:1–4.
- g (1:11) Hebrew Adonai.
- h (1:11) The cupbearer tasted and served the king's wine and was a trusted official with close access to the king.

Chapter 2

1 In the month of Nisan (March–April),[a] in the twentieth year of King
Artaxerxes,[b] wine was set before him, and I took it and handed it to
the king. I had never been sad in his presence before. 2 The king asked
me, "Why do you look so sad, when you are not ill? This can only
be sorrow of the heart." I was terrified. 3 And I answered the king,
"May the king live forever! How could my face not be sad, when the
city where my fathers are buried lies waste and its gates are eaten up
with fire?" 4 The king said to me, "For what are you asking?" And I
prayed to the God of heaven. 5 I answered the king, "If it please the
king, and if your servant has gained your favor, send me to Judah,
to the city where my ancestors are buried, so that I can rebuild it." 6
Then the king, with the queen[c] seated beside him, asked me, "How
long will your trip take, and when will you come back?" It pleased
the king to send me, so I named a time. 7 And I said to the king, "If
it pleases the king, let letters be given me to the governors of the
province Beyond the River,[d] that they may let me pass through until
I come to Judah, 8 and a letter to Asaph, who keeps the king's park,[e]
directing him to give me timber for beams for the gates of the citadel
beside the temple, for the city wall, and for the house I am to occupy."

And the king gave me these things, because the good hand of my God was on me.
9 Then I came to the governors of the province Beyond the River and gave them the king's letters. Now the king had sent with me officers of the army and horsemen. 10 When Sanballat the Horonite[f] and Tobiah the servant, the Ammonite,[g] heard of it, it was a great evil in their eyes that a man had come to seek good for the sons of Israel.
11 So I came to Jerusalem and was there three days. 12 I got up during the night, along with a few men. I told no one what my God had put in my heart to do for Jerusalem. I took no animal except the one I was riding. 13 That night I went out through the Valley Gate toward the Dragon Spring[h] and the Dung Gate, examining the walls of Jerusalem, which were broken down,[i] and its gates, which had been destroyed by fire. 14 Then I passed on to the Fountain Gate and the King's Pool, but there was no space for the beast I rode to get through. 15 So I went up the valley[j] during the night, examining the wall. Then I turned back and came in again through the Valley Gate. 16 The officials had no knowledge of where I went or what I did, for up to then I had told nothing to the Jews, to the priests, nobles, and officials, or to the rest who were to do the work.
17 Then I told them, "You can see the trouble we are in: Jerusalem is a ruin, and its gates have been burned. Come, let us rebuild the wall of Jerusalem and put an end to our disgrace." 18 I told them how kindly my God's hand had been on me, and what the king had said to me. They answered, "Let's start building!" And they set their hands to the good work.
19 But Sanballat the Horonite, Tobiah the Ammonite official, and Geshem the Arab[k] heard about it and ridiculed and scorned us. "What are you doing?" they asked. "Are you rebelling against the king?"
20 I replied, "The God of heaven will make us prosper. We are his servants, and we will begin to build. But you have no share, claim, or historic right in Jerusalem."

Notes

- a (2:1) Hebrew Nisan, the first month, which fell in March–April; here spring 445 BC.

- b (2:1) Artaxerxes I Longimanus, king of Persia 465–424 BC.
- c (2:6) Hebrew shegal, a royal consort, perhaps the chief queen.
- d (2:7) The Persian province west of the Euphrates, which included Syria and Judah.
- e (2:8) Hebrew pardes, a Persian loanword for a park or enclosed royal woodland; it is the source of the word "paradise."
- f (2:10) Sanballat (Babylonian Sin-uballiṭ, "Sin [the moon god] has given life") was governor of Samaria, as the Elephantine papyri show. "Horonite" probably means from Beth-horon.
- g (2:10) Or "official." Tobiah means "Yahweh is good"; he was probably governor of Ammon, east of the Jordan.
- h (2:13) Or "Jackal Spring."
- i (2:13) So the traditional reading (qere), "which they were broken down"; the written text (ketiv) has a different form of the same verb.
- j (2:15) The Kidron Valley, east of the city.
- k (2:19) Geshem (Arabic Jashm) is known from an inscribed silver bowl as a king of Kedar, a powerful Arab confederation in the northern Arabian desert.

Chapter 3

1 Eliashib the high priest and his fellow priests set to work and rebuilt
the Sheep Gate. They consecrated it and set up its doors, consecrating
the wall as far as the Tower of the Hundred[a] and the Tower of
Hananel. 2 Next to him the men of Jericho built. And next to them
Zaccur son of Imri built.
3 The sons of Hassenaah built the Fish Gate. They laid its beams and
set up its doors, its bolts, and its bars. 4 At their hand Meremoth
son of Uriah, son of Hakkoz, repaired. At his hand Meshullam son
of Berechiah, son of Meshezabel, repaired. At his hand Zadok son of
Baana repaired. 5 And next to them the Tekoites made repairs, but
their nobles would not bend their necks to the work of their lords.[b]
6 Joiada son of Paseah and Meshullam son of Besodeiah repaired the
Old Gate.[c] They laid its beams and set up its doors, its bolts, and
its bars. 7 And next to them Melatiah the Gibeonite and Jadon the
Meronothite, the men of Gibeon and of Mizpah, made repairs, up
to the seat of the governor of the province Beyond the River.[d] 8 At
his hand Uzziel son of Harhaiah, of the goldsmiths, repaired; and at
his hand Hananiah, a member of the perfumers, repaired. They left[e]
Jerusalem whole up to the Broad Wall. 9 At their hand Rephaiah son of

Hur, who governed half the district of Jerusalem, repaired. 10 At their
hand Jedaiah son of Harumaph repaired, across from his house; and
at his hand Hattush son of Hashabneiah repaired. 11 A second section,
together with the Tower of the Ovens, was repaired by Malchijah son
of Harim and Hasshub son of Pahath-moab. 12 At his hand Shallum son
of Hallohesh, who governed half the district of Jerusalem, repaired,
together with his daughters.
13 The Valley Gate was repaired by Hanun and the people living in
Zanoah. They built it and hung its doors with their bolts and bars,
and repaired 1,500 feet[f] of wall up to the Dung Gate.
14 Malchijah son of Rechab, ruler of the district of Beth-haccherem,
repaired the Dung Gate. He rebuilt it and set up its doors, its bolts,
and its bars.
15 Shallun son of Col-hozeh, ruler of the district of Mizpah, repaired
the Fountain Gate. He rebuilt it, covered it with a roof, and set up its
doors[g] with their bolts and bars. He also repaired the wall of the Pool
of Shelah[h] by the king's garden, as far as the stairs that descend from
the City of David. 16 After him Nehemiah son of Azbuk, who governed
half the district of Beth-zur, repaired up to a point across from David's
tombs, to the pool that had been made, and to the House of the
Warriors. 17 After him the Levites repaired: Rehum son of Bani; at his
hand Hashabiah, who governed half the district of Keilah, repaired for
his own district. 18 After him their brothers made repairs: Bavvai[i] son
of Henadad, ruler of half the district of Keilah. 19 At his hand Ezer son
of Jeshua, who governed Mizpah, repaired a second section, across
from the way up to the armory at the Angle. 20 After him Baruch son
of Zabbai[j] worked eagerly[k] on a second section, from the Angle to the
doorway of the house of Eliashib the high priest. 21 After him Mere-
moth son of Uriah, son of Hakkoz, repaired a second section, from the
doorway of Eliashib's house to where Eliashib's house ended. 22 After
him the priests, the men of the surrounding district,[l] made repairs. 23
After them Benjamin and Hasshub made repairs opposite their house.
After them Azariah son of Maaseiah, son of Ananiah, made repairs
beside his own house. 24 After him Binnui son of Henadad repaired a
second section, from Azariah's house up to the Angle and the corner.

25 Palal son of Uzai worked on the section opposite the Angle and the
tower that stands out from the upper house of the king, beside the
court of the guard. Next in line came Pedaiah son of Parosh 26 while
the temple servants who lived on the Ophel[m] repaired up to a point
across from the Water Gate toward the east and the tower that juts
out. 27 After them the men of Tekoa repaired a second section, across
from the great tower that juts out, up to the wall of the Ophel.
28 From above the Horse Gate the priests repaired, every man across
from his own house. 29 After them Zadok son of Immer repaired
across from his house; after him Shemaiah son of Shecaniah, keeper
of the East Gate, repaired. 30 After him[n] Hananiah son of Shelemiah
and Hanun, Zalaph's sixth son, repaired a second section. After him
Meshullam son of Berechiah repaired across from his own room. 31
After him Malchijah, a member of the goldsmiths, repaired up to
the house of the temple servants and the traders, across from the
Muster Gate,[o] and up to the corner's upper room. 32 And between the
upper room of the corner and the Sheep Gate the goldsmiths and the
merchants made repairs.

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew the Tower of Hammeah. Its name may refer to its height of a hundred cubits (about 150 feet or 45 meters) or to a hundred steps.
- b (3:5) Or "their Lord."
- c (3:6) Or "the Jeshanah Gate," naming the town of Jeshanah, toward which it faced.
- d (3:7) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; possibly "who were under the jurisdiction of the governor."
- e (3:8) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; usually "left," here perhaps "paved" or "restored."
- f (3:13) Hebrew "a thousand cubits," about 1,500 feet or 450 meters.
- g (3:15) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "and they set up."
- h (3:15) Shelah, "channel," is the pool fed by Hezekiah's tunnel, called Siloam (Shiloah) in Isaiah 8:6 and John 9:7.
- i (3:18) Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint and Syriac have Binnui (see verse 24).
- j (3:20) So the written text (ketiv); the traditional reading (qere) is Zaccai.
- k (3:20) Hebrew heḥerah, literally "burned," that is, with zeal. The word is uncertain and may have arisen by copying; the Septuagint lacks it.

- l (3:22) Hebrew kikkar, “circle,” the Jordan Valley around Jericho, or the region around Jerusalem.
- m (3:26) The Ophel (“swelling,” “hill”) was the ridge between the City of David and the temple mount.
- n (3:30) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has “after me.” Likewise in verse 31.
- o (3:31) Or “the Inspection Gate”; Hebrew the Miphkad Gate.

Chapter 4

1 When Sanballat heard that we were rebuilding the wall, he became furious and was deeply angered. He ridiculed the Jews,[a] 2 He spoke before his brothers and the army of Samaria and said, “What are these weak Jews up to? Will they leave it to themselves? Will they offer sacrifice? Will they be done in a day? Will they bring the stones back to life out of the rubbish heaps, burned stones at that?” 3 And Tobiah the Ammonite, standing beside him, said, “Let them build—if a fox climbed on that stone wall of theirs, it would break it down!”

4 Hear us, our God, for we are scorned! Bring their insults back on their own heads, and hand them over as spoil in a land where they are captives. 5 Do not cover over their guilt, and do not let their sin be wiped away before you, for they have insulted you in front of the builders.[b] 6 So we built the wall, and all the wall was joined together up to half its height, for the people had a heart to work.

7 But when it came to the ears of Sanballat and Tobiah, the Arabs, the Ammonites, and the Ashdodites that healing had come to the walls of Jerusalem and that the gaps had begun to close, their anger blazed. 8 And they all plotted together to come and fight against Jerusalem and to cause confusion in it. 9 And we prayed to our God, and because of them we posted a watch against them by day and by night.

10 Meanwhile the people of Judah were saying, “The laborers are growing weak, and there is so much rubble that we cannot work on the wall.” 11 And our enemies said, “They will not know or see until we come into their midst and kill them and stop the work.” 12 Then the Jews who lived near them kept coming and warning us again and again, “They will attack us from every place you turn.”[c] 13 So in the lowest parts of the space behind the wall, in the open places,[d] I

stationed the people by their families, with their swords, their spears, and their bows. 14 After looking things over, I stood up and said to the nobles, the officials, and the rest of the people, "Do not be afraid of them. Remember the Lord,[e] who is great and awesome, and fight for your relatives, your sons and daughters, your wives, and your homes."
15 Once our enemies heard that we knew of it, and that God had broken up their plan, all of us went back[f] to the wall, every man to his own task. 16 From then on, half of my young men did the work while half of them held the spears, the shields, the bows, and the armor; and the officers stood behind all the house of Judah 17 who were building the wall. The men carrying loads did their work with one hand, while the other hand held a weapon. 18 Every builder worked with his sword fastened at his waist, and the trumpeter stood next to me. 19 Then I said to the nobles, the officials, and the rest of the people, "The work is large and spread out, and we are far apart from one another along the wall. 20 Wherever you hear the trumpet blast, gather to us at that spot. Our God will fight for us."
21 So we went on with the work, half of them holding spears, from first light until the stars appeared. 22 At that time I also told the people, "Every man and his servant must spend the night inside Jerusalem. Then they can serve as our guard at night and as workers by day."
23 So none of us—not I, not my brothers, not my young men, not the guardsmen behind me—took off our clothes; each one kept his weapon at his right hand.[g]

Notes

- a (4:1) In the Hebrew text, verses 1–6 of this chapter are numbered 3:33–38, and verses 7–23 are numbered 4:1–17. This translation follows the verse numbering of the standard English Bible. The Septuagint follows the Hebrew numbering.
- b (4:5) Or "they have hurled insults in front of the builders."
- c (4:12) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (4:13) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a variant spelling.
- e (4:14) Hebrew Adonai.
- f (4:15) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "and we will return."
- g (4:23) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; literally "each his weapon, the water."

Chapter 5

1 Then a great cry went up from the people and their wives against
their brothers the Jews. 2 Some were saying, "We and our sons and
daughters are many. We must get grain to eat so that we can survive."
3 Others said, "We are putting up our fields, vineyards, and houses
as security to get grain during the famine." 4 Others said, "We have
had to borrow silver to pay the king's tribute on our fields and
vineyards. 5 We are the same flesh and blood as our fellow Israelites,
and our children are as good as theirs. Yet we are forcing our sons and
daughters into slavery. Some of our daughters are already enslaved,
and we are powerless to stop it, because other men now own our
fields and vineyards."
6 I was very angry when I heard their outcry and these words. 7
I thought it over and then brought charges against the nobles and
officials. I told them, "You are charging interest[a] to your own people!"
I also called a large assembly against them 8 and I told them, "As far as
was in our power, we have redeemed our brothers the Jews who were
sold to the nations—and now you yourselves sell your brothers, so
that they must be sold back to us?" They kept quiet and found nothing
to answer. 9 And I said,[b] "What you do is not good. Should you not
walk in the fear of our God, so that the nations, our enemies, have no
cause to reproach us? 10 I too, and my brothers and my young men,
have been lending them silver and grain. Let us give up this lending
on interest. 11 Give back to them, today, their fields, vineyards, olive
orchards, and houses, and the percentage[c] on the silver, grain, new
wine, and oil that you have been charging them." 12 They answered,
"We will give it back and demand nothing of them; we will do just
what you say." Then I summoned the priests and put the men under
oath to keep this promise. 13 I shook out the front of my robe as well
and said, "Thus may God shake out of his house and out of the fruit
of his labor every man who does not carry out this word; thus may
he be shaken out and left empty." And all the assembly said, "Amen,"
and praised Yahweh. And the people kept this word.
14 Furthermore, from the day I was appointed their governor in the
land of Judah, from the twentieth year until the thirty-second year of

King Artaxerxes[d] (twelve years), neither I nor my relatives drew the governor's food allowance. 15 The governors before me had weighed down the people and taken bread and wine from them, as well as about a pound of silver.[e] Their young men also domineered over the people. But I did not act like that, because I feared God. 16 Instead, I devoted myself to the work on this wall. We bought no land, and all my servants were gathered there to work. 17 There were at my table, besides, 150 Jews and officials, not counting those who came to us from the surrounding nations. 18 What was made ready daily at my cost was one ox and six choice sheep, and fowl as well, and once every ten days a great supply of all kinds of wine. Even so, I never asked for the bread of the governor, because the labor weighed heavily on this people. 19 O my God, remember me for good, for all I have done for this people.

Notes

- a (5:7) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a variant spelling. The meaning is "lending on pledge," or "taking interest."
- b (5:9) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "and he said."
- c (5:11) Hebrew "the hundredth," probably a charge of one percent a month, or twelve percent a year.
- d (5:14) From 445 to 433 BC.
- e (5:15) Hebrew "40 shekels of silver," about 1 pound (460 grams), probably a daily charge.

Chapter 6

1 When Sanballat, Tobiah, Geshem the Arab, and the rest of our enemies heard that I had rebuilt the wall and that not a gap remained in it (though I had not yet set up the doors in the gates), 2 Sanballat and Geshem sent me this message: "Come, let us meet with one another at Hakkephirim[a] in the plain of Ono." But they were planning to do me evil. 3 And I sent messengers to them, saying, "I am doing a great work and I cannot come down. Why should the work stop while I leave it and come down to you?" 4 They sent me word in this manner four times, and four times I answered them in the same manner. 5 Then a fifth time Sanballat sent his young man to me in the same way, carrying an unsealed letter. 6 It said: "A rumor is going around

among the nations, and Gashmu[b] says it is true, that you and the Jews are plotting to rebel, and that this is why you are building the wall. According to these reports, you are going to become their king. 7 You have even appointed prophets to announce in Jerusalem about you, 'There is a king in Judah!' Now these reports will reach the king. So come now, and let us consult with each other." 8 I sent back to him, "Nothing has happened like what you are saying; you are making it up in your own mind." 9 They were all trying to scare us, thinking, "They will lose heart for the work, and it will never be finished." But now, strengthen my hands![c]

10 Then I went to the house of Shemaiah son of Delaiah, son of Mehetabel, who was shut in. He said, "Let us meet at the house of God, inside the temple, and shut the temple doors; for they are coming to kill you—by night they are coming to kill you." 11 I replied, "Should a man like me flee? And who that is such as I could enter the temple and keep his life?[d] I will not go in." 12 Then I perceived that God had not sent him at all; he had spoken this prophecy against me because Tobiah and Sanballat had paid him. 13 He had been paid so that I would take fright, act this way, and sin; then they would have an evil report with which to reproach me. 14 Remember, my God, what Tobiah and Sanballat have done, and also the prophetess Noadiah and the rest of the prophets who kept trying to intimidate me.

15 So the wall was finished on the twenty-fifth day of the month Elul (August–September),[e] in fifty-two days. 16 When all our enemies heard, all the nations surrounding us were afraid and were greatly cast down in their own eyes, for they knew that this work had been done by our God. 17 Moreover, in those days the nobles of Judah sent many letters to Tobiah, and Tobiah's letters came to them. 18 For there were many in Judah sworn to him, since he was son-in-law to Shecaniah son of Arah, and Jehohanan his son had married the daughter of Meshullam son of Berechiah. 19 They also kept telling me of his good deeds, and they carried my words out to him. And Tobiah sent letters to frighten me.

Notes

- a (6:2) Or "in one of the villages."

- b (6:6) Gashmu is another form of the name Geshem.
- c (6:9) A brief prayer; the Hebrew does not name God here. The Septuagint reads "And now I strengthened my hands."
- d (6:11) Nehemiah was not a priest; for a layman to enter the temple building was forbidden (Numbers 18:7).
- e (6:15) Hebrew Elul, the sixth month, which fell in August–September; in 445 BC its twenty-fifth day fell about the beginning of October. Fifty-two days of work means the building began early in the fifth month, Av (July–August).

Chapter 7

1 When the wall was built and I had hung the doors, and the gate-
keepers, the singers, and the Levites were appointed, 2 I put Jerusalem
in the charge of Hanani my brother and of Hananiah, the commander
of the citadel, for he was a faithful man who feared God beyond many.
3 And I said[a] to them, "The gates of Jerusalem must stay closed until
the sun is hot; while the gatekeepers stand at their posts, have them
close the doors and fasten them. And set watches drawn from those
who live in Jerusalem, every man at his station and every man in front
of his house." 4 Now the city was broad and large, with few people in
it, and the houses had not been built.
5 And my God put it into my heart to bring together the nobles, the
officials, and the people, to enroll them by their genealogy. I came
upon the register of the genealogy of those who came up at the
beginning, and I found in it this record:[b]
6 These are the people of the province who came back from captivity
in exile, the ones King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon had deported.
They returned to Jerusalem and Judah, each to his own town. 7
They came with Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Azariah,[c] Raamiah,
Nahamani, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispereth, Bigvai, Nehum, Baanah.
The number of the men of the people of Israel: 8 the sons of Parosh,
2,172; 9 the sons of Shephatiah, 372; 10 the sons of Arah, 652; 11 the sons
of Pahath-moab, of the sons of Jeshua and Joab, 2,818; 12 the sons of
Elam, 1,254; 13 the sons of Zattu, 845; 14 the sons of Zaccai, 760; 15 the
sons of Binnui, 648; 16 the sons of Bebai, 628; 17 the sons of Azgad, 2,322;
18 the sons of Adonikam, 667; 19 the sons of Bigvai, 2,067; 20 the sons of
Adin, 655; 21 the sons of Ater, of Hezekiah, 98; 22 the sons of Hashum,

328; 23 the sons of Bezai, 324; 24 the sons of Hariph, 112; 25 the sons of Gibeon, 95; 26 the men of Bethlehem and Netophah, 188; 27 the men of Anathoth, 128; 28 the men of Beth-azmaveth, 42; 29 the men of Kiriath-jearim, Chephirah, and Beeroth, 743; 30 the men of Ramah and Geba, 621; 31 the men of Michmas, 122; 32 the men of Bethel and Ai, 123; 33 the men of the other Nebo, 52; 34 the sons of the other Elam, 1,254; 35 the sons of Harim, 320; 36 the sons of Jericho, 345; 37 the sons of Lod, Hadid, and Ono, 721; 38 the sons of Senaah, 3,930.

39 The priests: the sons of Jedaiah, of the house of Jeshua, 973; 40 the sons of Immer, 1,052; 41 the sons of Pashhur, 1,247; 42 the sons of Harim, 1,017.

43 The Levites: the descendants of Jeshua, that is, of Kadmiel through the line of Hodevah, 74. 44 The singers: the sons of Asaph, 148. 45 The gatekeepers: the sons of Shallum and Ater, Talmon and Akkub, Hatita and Shobai, totaling 138.

46 The temple servants: the sons of Ziha, of Hasupha, of Tabbaoth, 47 the sons of Keros, of Sia, of Padon, 48 the sons of Lebana, of Hagaba, of Shalmai, 49 the sons of Hanan, of Giddel, of Gahar, 50 the sons of Reaiah, of Rezin, of Nekoda, 51 the sons of Gazzam, of Uzza, of Paseah, 52 the sons of Besai, of Meunim, of Nephushesim,[d] 53 the sons of Bakbuk, of Hakupha, of Harhur, 54 the sons of Bazlith, of Mehida, of Harsha, 55 the sons of Barkos, of Sisera, of Temah, 56 the sons of Neziah, and of Hatipha.

57 Of Solomon's servants: the sons of Sotai, of Sophereth, of Perida, 58 the sons of Jaala, of Darkon, of Giddel, 59 the sons of Shephatiah, of Hattil, of Pochereth-hazzebaim, and of Amon. 60 The temple servants together with the sons of Solomon's servants totaled 392.

61 And these went up from Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addon, and Immer, but they were unable to show their fathers' house and their lineage, whether they were of Israel: 62 the sons of Delaiah, of Tobiah, and of Nekoda, 642. 63 And from the priests: the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai (this man had married one of the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite and taken their name). 64 These searched for their entry among those enrolled in the genealogies, but it was not found, and so they were barred from the priesthood as

unclean. 65 The governor[e] told them that they were not to eat any of
the most holy food until a priest should arise to consult the Urim and
Thummim.
66 The whole assembly together was 42,360, 67 besides their male and
female servants, who were 7,337. And they had 245 singing men and
singing women. 68 Their horses were 736, their mules 245,[f] 69 their
camels 435, and their donkeys 6,720.
70 Some of the family heads contributed to the work. The governor
gave the treasury 1,000 gold darics (about 18½ pounds of gold),[g] 50
bowls, and 530 priestly garments. 71 Some of the family heads gave the
treasury for the work 20,000 gold darics (about 370 pounds of gold)[h]
and about 1⅓ tons of silver.[i] 72 And what the rest of the people gave
was 20,000 gold darics (about 370 pounds of gold), about 1¼ tons of
silver,[j] and 67 priests' garments.
73 The priests, Levites, gatekeepers, singers, some of the people,
the temple servants, and all the rest of Israel settled in their own
towns. When the seventh month (September–October)[k] arrived, the
Israelites were living in their towns.

Notes

- a (7:3) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has "and he said."
- b (7:5) Verses 6–73 repeat Ezra 2:1–70 with many small differences in names and numbers.
- c (7:7) Ezra 2:2 has Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mispar, and Rehum for Azariah, Raamiah, Mispereth, and Nehum, and lacks Nahamani.
- d (7:52) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Nephushsim.
- e (7:65) Hebrew Tirshatha, a Persian title, perhaps "His Excellency." See Ezra 2:63.
- f (7:68) This verse is lacking in most Hebrew manuscripts; it is supplied from some manuscripts and from Ezra 2:66. As a result, verses 69–73 in this translation are numbered 68–72 in the Hebrew.
- g (7:70) Hebrew darkemonim, the Persian gold daric (or perhaps the Greek drachma). A daric weighed about 0.3 ounce (8.4 grams), so 1,000 darics weighed about 8.4 kilograms.
- h (7:71) That is, about 168 kilograms.
- i (7:71) Hebrew "2,200 minas of silver." A mina was about 1¼ pounds (575 grams), so 2,200 minas is about 2,750 pounds (1,265 kilograms).
- j (7:72) Hebrew "2,000 minas of silver," about 2,500 pounds (1,150 kilograms).
- k (7:73) Hebrew "the seventh month," Tishri, which fell in September–October; here the autumn of 445 BC.

Chapter 8

1 All the people assembled together in the square in front of the Water
Gate. They asked Ezra the scribe to bring out the Book of the Law
of Moses, which Yahweh had given to Israel.[a] 2 So on the first day
of the seventh month (September–October),[b] Ezra the priest brought
the Law before the assembly of men and women and everyone able
to understand what they heard. 3 He read in it before the square in
front of the Water Gate from first light until midday, before the men
and women and all who could understand; and all the people listened
closely to the Book of the Law. 4 Ezra the scribe stood on a wooden
platform[c] made for this purpose. Beside him on his right stood
Mattithiah, Shema, Anaiah, Uriah, Hilkiah, and Maaseiah; and on
his left stood Pedaiah, Mishael, Malchijah, Hashum, Hashbaddanah,
Zechariah, and Meshullam. 5 And Ezra opened the book in the sight
of all the people, for he was above all the people, and as he opened it
all the people stood. 6 And Ezra blessed Yahweh, the great God, and
all the people answered, "Amen, Amen," lifting up their hands. And
they bowed their heads and worshiped Yahweh with their faces to the
ground. 7 Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah,
Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, and Pelaiah—the Levites
—were explaining the Law to the people, as the people stood in their
places. 8 They read in the book, in the Law of God, distinctly,[d] and
they gave the meaning, and made the reading understood.
9 Then Nehemiah the governor,[e] Ezra the priest and scribe, and the
Levites who were teaching the people told everyone, "This day is holy
to Yahweh your God. Do not mourn or weep." The people had all
been weeping as they heard the words of the Law. 10 Nehemiah said,
"Go and enjoy rich food and sweet drinks, and send some to anyone
who has nothing ready, since this day is holy to our Lord.[f] Do not
be sad, for the joy of Yahweh is your strength." 11 The Levites, too,
were quieting all the people and saying, "Hush, for the day is holy;
do not grieve." 12 Then all the people went off to eat and drink, to send
portions to others, and to celebrate with great joy, because they had
grasped the words that were explained to them.

13 On the second day, the heads of families from among all the people,
together with the priests and Levites, gathered around Ezra the scribe
to study the words of the Law. 14 And they found it written in the
Law that Yahweh had commanded by Moses that the sons of Israel
should dwell in booths during the feast of the seventh month,[g] 15 and
that they were to announce and spread the word through all their
towns and in Jerusalem: "Go out to the hill country and fetch boughs
of olive and of wild olive, of myrtle and palm and other leafy trees, to
make booths, as it is written." 16 So the people went out and brought
branches and built themselves booths, each on his own roof, in their
courtyards, in the courtyards of God's house, and in the squares by
the Water Gate and the Gate of Ephraim. 17 So the whole assembly
who had come back from the captivity made booths and dwelt in
them; for since the days of Jeshua[h] son of Nun until that day the sons
of Israel had not done it. And the joy was exceedingly great. 18 And
day by day, from the first day to the last day, he read from the Book
of the Law of God. They kept the feast seven days, and on the eighth
day there was a solemn assembly, according to the rule.

Notes

- a (8:1) Nehemiah 7:73b–8:12 is retold in the Greek book 1 Esdras (9:37–55), which ends with this scene.
- b (8:2) Hebrew "the first day of the seventh month," the day of trumpet blasts (Leviticus 23:24), which later became the Jewish New Year (Rosh Hashanah).
- c (8:4) Hebrew "a tower of wood."
- d (8:8) Or "with interpretation," perhaps meaning that the Hebrew was explained or translated into Aramaic, the everyday language of the time.
- e (8:9) Hebrew Tirshatha, a Persian title; see Ezra 2:63.
- f (8:10) Hebrew Adonai.
- g (8:14) See Leviticus 23:33–43. The Feast of Booths (Sukkot, or Tabernacles) began on the fifteenth day of the seventh month (September–October).
- h (8:17) Jeshua is a later form of the name Joshua.

Chapter 9

1 On the twenty-fourth day of this month (in September–October)[a]
the sons of Israel gathered, fasting, wearing sackcloth, with dust
upon them. 2 And the offspring of Israel separated themselves from
all foreigners and stood and confessed their sins and the iniquities

of their fathers. 3 And they stood up in their place and read from
the Book of the Law of Yahweh their God for about three hours;[b] for
another three hours they made confession and worshiped Yahweh
their God.
4 On the stairs of the Levites stood Jeshua, Bani, Kadmiel, Shebaniah,
Bunni, Sherebiah, Bani, and Chenani, and they called out loudly to
Yahweh their God. 5 Then the Levites, Jeshua, Kadmiel, Bani, Hashab-
neiah, Sherebiah, Hodiah, Shebaniah, and Pethahiah, said, "Stand up
and bless Yahweh your God from everlasting to everlasting. Blessed
be your glorious name, which is exalted above all blessing and praise.
6 "You alone are Yahweh.[c] You made the heavens, even the highest
heavens, with all their host; the earth and everything on it; the seas
and everything in them. You give life to all of them, and the host of
heaven bows down to you. 7 You are Yahweh God, who chose Abram,
brought him out from Ur of the Chaldeans, and named him Abraham.[d]
8 You found his heart faithful toward you and cut a covenant with
him to give the land of the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites,
Jebusites, and Girgashites—to give it to his seed. And you have
fulfilled your words, because you are righteous.
9 "And you saw the affliction of our fathers in Egypt and heard their
cry at the Red Sea,[e] 10 You gave signs and wonders against Pharaoh,
against all his servants, and against all the people of his land, for you
knew how proudly they dealt with them; and you made yourself a
name that remains to this day. 11 And you divided the sea before them,
so that they went through the midst of the sea on dry land, and you
cast their pursuers into the depths, as a stone into mighty waters. 12 By
a pillar of cloud you led them by day, and by a pillar of fire by night,
to light for them the way in which they should go. 13 You came down
on Mount Sinai and spoke with them from heaven. You gave them
just rulings and true laws, and good decrees and commands. 14 You
made your holy Sabbath known to them, and through your servant
Moses you gave them commands, decrees, and a law. 15 When they
were hungry you gave them bread from heaven, and when they were
thirsty you brought them water from the rock. You told them to go in
and take over the land you had promised with an oath to give them.

16 “But they, our fathers, behaved proudly; they hardened their necks
and would not listen to your commandments. 17 They would not listen;
they did not call to mind your wonders that you had done among
them, but hardened their necks and in their rebellion set up a head to
go back to their bondage.[f] But you are a God of pardons, gracious and
compassionate, long-suffering and great in steadfast love,[g] and you
did not abandon them. 18 Even when they cast for themselves an image
of a calf and said, ‘This is your God, who brought you up out of Egypt,’
and committed terrible blasphemies, 19 you did not abandon them in
the desert, because of your great compassion. By day the pillar of
cloud did not leave them but guided them on their path, and by night
the pillar of fire lit up the way they were to go. 20 You gave your good
Spirit to teach them. You did not hold back your manna from their
mouths, and you gave them water when they were thirsty. 21 For forty
years you fed them in the wilderness; they wanted for nothing. Their
garments did not wear out, and their feet did not swell. 22 You gave
them kingdoms and peoples and parceled them out as a border.[h] They
took the land of Sihon—that is,[i] the land of the king of Heshbon—and
the land of Og king of Bashan as their own. 23 You made their sons as
many as the stars of the sky, and you brought them into the land of
which you had told their fathers that they would go in to possess it.
24 So their descendants entered and took possession of the land. You
subdued the Canaanites who lived there and handed them over to
your people, along with their kings and the peoples of the land, to
deal with as they wished. 25 They took strong cities and fertile ground,
and came to own houses filled with every good thing, cisterns dug
out, vineyards, olive groves, and fruit trees in plenty. They ate, were
satisfied, grew fat, and reveled in your great goodness.
26 “Yet they disobeyed and rebelled against you; they threw your law
behind their backs and killed your prophets, who testified against
them to bring them back to you; and they committed great contempt.
27 So you handed them over to their foes, who oppressed them. In their
time of distress they cried to you, and you heard from heaven, and
in your great compassion you gave them saviors to save them out of
the hand of their foes. 28 Yet as soon as they had relief, they went back

to doing evil before you. So you abandoned them to their enemies, who ruled over them. Again they cried out to you, and from heaven you heard and delivered them, time after time, in your compassion.
29 You testified against them to bring them back to your law, but they acted proudly and would not listen to your commandments; they sinned against your ordinances, by which a man who does them shall live.[j] They turned away a defiant shoulder, hardened their necks, and would not listen. 30 For many years you put up with them and warned them by your Spirit through your prophets, but they would not pay attention. So you gave them into the hands of the peoples around them. 31 Yet in your abundant compassion you did not make a full end of them or abandon them, for you are a God gracious and compassionate.
32 "And now, our God, great, mighty, and awesome God, who keeps covenant and faithful love: do not let all the hardship that has come on us seem small to you, on our kings, our officials, our priests, our prophets, our ancestors, and all your people, from the time of the kings of Assyria until today. 33 You are in the right in all that has come on us; you have acted in faithfulness, while we have done wickedly.
34 Our kings, our officials, our priests, and our fathers have not done your law, nor heeded your commandments and the testimonies with which you warned them. 35 In their kingdom, with the great goodness you gave them, and in the broad and fertile land you put before them, they did not serve you, nor did they turn back from their evil deeds. 36 Look—today we are slaves, slaves in the very land you gave our fathers to eat its fruit and its good things. 37 Its plentiful harvest belongs to the kings whom you set over us because of our sins; they have power over our bodies and our cattle at their pleasure, and we are in great distress.
38 "For all this we are making a sure agreement and writing it, and on the sealed copy are our officials, our Levites, and our priests."[k]

Notes

- a (9:1) Hebrew "the twenty-fourth day of this month," the seventh month, Tishri, two days after the close of the Feast of Booths.

- b (9:3) Hebrew “a quarter of the day.” The daylight hours were about twelve, so a quarter was about three hours.
- c (9:6) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a shorter spelling of “you.” The Septuagint begins the verse “And Ezra said.”
- d (9:7) Abram means “exalted father”; Abraham was understood as “father of a multitude” (Genesis 17:5).
- e (9:9) Hebrew Yam Suph, “Sea of Reeds.”
- f (9:17) So the traditional Hebrew text. Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint read “in Egypt,” that is, “set up a head to return to their bondage in Egypt” (compare Numbers 14:4).
- g (9:17) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has “and steadfast love.”
- h (9:22) Or “allotted them as a boundary.”
- i (9:22) Or “and.”
- j (9:29) See Leviticus 18:5.
- k (9:38) In the Hebrew text this verse is 10:1, and 10:1–39 is numbered 10:2–40.

Chapter 10

1 On the seals were the names of[a] Nehemiah the governor, the son of
Hacaliah, and Zedekiah, 2 Seraiah, Azariah, and Jeremiah, 3 Pashhur,
Amariah, and Malchijah, 4 Hattush, Shebaniah, and Malluch, 5 Harim,
Meremoth, and Obadiah, 6 Daniel, Ginnethon, and Baruch, 7 Meshul-
lam, Abijah, and Mijamin, 8 Maaziah, Bilgai, and Shemaiah. These
were the priests. 9 And the Levites: Jeshua son of Azaniah, Binnui
of the sons of Henadad, Kadmiel; 10 and their relatives Shebaniah,
Hodiah, Kelita, Pelaiah, and Hanan, 11 Mica, Rehob, and Hashabiah,
12 Zaccur, Sherebiah, and Shebaniah, 13 Hodiah, Bani, and Beninu. 14
The leaders of the people: Parosh, Pahath-moab, Elam, Zattu, and
Bani, 15 Bunni, Azgad, and Bebai, 16 Adonijah, Bigvai, and Adin, 17
Ater, Hezekiah, and Azzur, 18 Hodiah, Hashum, and Bezai, 19 Hariph,
Anathoth, and Nebai,[b] 20 Magpiash, Meshullam, and Hezir, 21 Meshez-
abel, Zadok, and Jaddua, 22 Pelatiah, Hanan, and Anaiah, 23 Hoshea,
Hananiah, and Hasshub, 24 Hallohesh, Pilha, and Shobek, 25 Rehum,
Hashabnah, and Maaseiah, 26 Ahiah, Hanan, and Anan, 27 Malluch,
Harim, and Baanah.

28 The rest of the people, including the priests, Levites, gatekeepers,
singers, temple servants, and all who had separated themselves from
the surrounding peoples to follow the Law of God, along with their

wives and all their sons and daughters who were old enough to understand, 29 they hold fast with their brothers, their nobles, and come under a curse and an oath to walk in the Law of God given through Moses, God's servant, and to keep and perform every commandment of Yahweh our Lord,[c] with his ordinances and statutes. 30 We will not give our daughters to the peoples of the land or take their daughters for our sons. 31 If the peoples of the land bring wares or grain of any sort on the day of the Sabbath to sell, we will buy none of it from them on a Sabbath or holy day. We will also let the seventh year lie fallow and give up the claim on every debt.[d]

32 We also accept the responsibility of giving each year an eighth of an ounce of silver[e] toward the service of the house of our God: 33 for the bread of the Presence, for the continual grain offering and the continual burnt offering, for the Sabbaths, new moons, and set feasts, for the holy offerings and the sin offerings that make atonement for Israel, and for every task of the house of our God. 34 We have also cast lots among the priests, Levites, and people for the wood offering, to bring it to the house of our God at set times each year, by our family groups, to burn on the altar of Yahweh our God, as the Law prescribes. 35 We obligate ourselves to bring the firstfruits of our ground and the firstfruits of all fruit of every tree, year by year, to the house of Yahweh; 36 also to bring to the house of our God, to the priests who minister in the house of our God, the firstborn of our sons and of our livestock, as it is written in the Law, and the firstborn of our herds and of our flocks; 37 We will also bring the first batch of our dough[f] and our contributions, the fruit of every kind of tree, the new wine, and the oil to the priests, at the storerooms of the house of our God, and a tenth of our crops to the Levites, since the Levites collect the tithes in all the towns where we work the soil. 38 A priest, a descendant of Aaron, is to be with the Levites when they collect the tithes, and the Levites are to take a tenth of those tithes up to the house of our God, to the rooms of the storehouse. 39 For into the storerooms the sons of Israel and the sons of Levi are to bring the contribution of grain, new wine, and oil; there are the holy vessels, and the priests who serve,

the gatekeepers, and the singers. We will not forsake the house of our God.

Notes

- a (10:1) Hebrew "Upon the sealed ones (were)."
- b (10:19) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Nobai.
- c (10:29) Hebrew Adonai, with the suffix "our."
- d (10:31) See Exodus 23:10–11; Deuteronomy 15:1–2.
- e (10:32) Hebrew "a third of a shekel," about ⅛ ounce (4 grams). Exodus 30:13 had required half a shekel.
- f (10:37) Or "dough."

Chapter 11

1 The leaders of the people settled in Jerusalem, and the rest of the people cast lots so that one in ten would come to dwell in Jerusalem the holy city and nine in ten in the towns. 2 And the people blessed all the men who willingly offered to live in Jerusalem.

3 These are the heads of the province who lived in Jerusalem; but in the towns of Judah each lived on his own property in their towns: Israel, the priests, the Levites, the temple servants, and the sons of Solomon's servants.[a] 4 Some of the people of Judah and Benjamin lived in Jerusalem. From Judah: Athaiah son of Uzziah, son of Zechariah, son of Amariah, son of Shephatiah, son of Mahalalel, a descendant of Perez; 5 and Maaseiah son of Baruch, son of Col-hozeh, son of Hazaiah, son of Adaiah, son of Joiarib, son of Zechariah, son of the Shilonite.[b] 6 All the sons of Perez who lived in Jerusalem were 468 valiant men.

7 And these are the sons of Benjamin: Sallu son of Meshullam, son of Joed, son of Pedaiah, son of Kolaiah, son of Maaseiah, son of Ithiel, son of Jeshaiah, 8 and after him Gabbai and Sallai,[c] 928. 9 Joel son of Zichri was overseer over them, and Judah son of Hassenuah was second in charge over the city.

10 Of the priests: Jedaiah son of Joiarib, Jachin, 11 Seraiah, son of Hilkiah, son of Meshullam, son of Zadok, son of Meraioth, son of Ahitub, the official in charge of God's house, 12 and their brothers who did the work of the house, 822; and Adaiah son of Jeroham, son of Pelaliah, son of Amzi, son of Zechariah, son of Pashhur, son

of Malchijah, 13 with his brothers, heads of fathers' houses, 242; and Amashsai son of Azarel, son of Ahzai, son of Meshillemoth, son of Immer, 14 and their brothers, valiant warriors, 128. Their overseer was Zabdiel son of Haggedolim.[d]

15 And of the Levites: Shemaiah son of Hasshub, son of Azrikam, son of Hashabiah, son of Bunni; 16 Shabbethai and Jozabad, from the heads of the Levites, over the outer work for the house of God; 17 Mattaniah son of Mica, son of Zabdi, son of Asaph, the leader who started the thanksgiving prayer; Bakbukiah, who ranked second among his relatives; and Abda son of Shammua, son of Galal, son of Jeduthun.[e] 18 All the Levites in the holy city were 284.

19 The gatekeepers, Akkub, Talmon, and their brothers, who kept watch at the gates, were 172. 20 And the rest of Israel, and of the priests and the Levites, were in all the towns of Judah, each in his inheritance. 21 But the temple servants lived on the Ophel; and Ziha and Gishpa were over the temple servants.

22 The chief officer of the Levites in Jerusalem was Uzzi son of Bani, son of Hashabiah, son of Mattaniah, son of Mica, from the descendants of Asaph, the singers responsible for the service of God's house. 23 For there was a command from the king concerning them, and a settled provision for the singers, as each day required. 24 And Pethahiah son of Meshezabel, of the sons of Zerah son of Judah, was at the king's hand[f] in all matters concerning the people.

25 As for the villages with their fields, some of the people of Judah lived in Kiriath-arba[g] and its surrounding villages,[h] in Dibon and its villages, and in Jekabzeel and its villages, 26 and in Jeshua and in Moladah and Beth-pelet, 27 in Hazar-shual, in Beersheba and its villages, 28 in Ziklag, in Meconah and its villages, 29 in En-rimmon, in Zorah, in Jarmuth, 30 Zanoah, Adullam, and their villages; Lachish with its fields; and Azekah with its villages. They settled from Beersheba all the way to the Valley of Hinnom. 31 The Benjaminites lived from Geba onward,[i] in Michmash, Aija, and Bethel with its villages, 32 Anathoth, Nob, Ananiah, 33 Hazor, Ramah, Gittaim, 34 Hadid, Zeboim, Neballat, 35 Lod, and Ono, the valley of craftsmen.[j] 36 And certain divisions of the Levites that were in Judah were joined to Benjamin.

Notes

- a (11:3) The list in verses 3–19 has a close parallel in 1 Chronicles 9:2–17, with many differences.
- b (11:5) Or "of the Shelanite," a descendant of Shelah son of Judah (Numbers 26:20).
- c (11:8) The Hebrew is uncertain; some read "and his brothers, valiant men."
- d (11:14) Or "son of the great ones," that is, of a leading family.
- e (11:17) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Jedithun.
- f (11:24) That is, the king's agent or adviser for the affairs of the Jews.
- g (11:25) The older name of Hebron (Genesis 23:2), "town of four" or "town of Arba."
- h (11:25) Hebrew "daughters." Likewise in verses 27, 28, 30, and 31.
- i (11:31) Or "The sons of Benjamin from Geba lived at Michmash…."
- j (11:35) Hebrew Ge-harashim.

Chapter 12

1 These are the priests and Levites who came up with Zerubbabel son
of Shealtiel, and with Jeshua: Seraiah, Jeremiah, and Ezra, 2 Amariah,
Malluch, and Hattush, 3 Shecaniah, Rehum, and Meremoth, 4 Iddo,
Ginnethoi, and Abijah, 5 Mijamin, Maadiah, and Bilgah, 6 Shemaiah,
Joiarib, and Jedaiah, 7 Sallu, Amok, Hilkiah, and Jedaiah. These were
the leaders of the priests and their fellow priests in the time of Jeshua.
8 The Levites were Jeshua, Binnui, Kadmiel, Sherebiah, Judah, and
Mattaniah; he and his brothers had charge of the thanksgiving songs.
9 Bakbukiah and Unni,[a] their brothers, stood across from them by
divisions.[b]
10 Jeshua fathered Joiakim; Joiakim fathered Eliashib; and Eliashib
fathered Joiada; 11 Joiada fathered Jonathan; and Jonathan fathered
Jaddua.[c]
12 And in the days of Joiakim were priests, heads of fathers' houses:
of Seraiah, Meraiah; of Jeremiah, Hananiah; 13 of Ezra, Meshullam; of
Amariah, Jehohanan; 14 of Melicu,[d] Jonathan; of Shebaniah, Joseph;
15 of Harim, Adna; of Meraioth, Helkai; 16 of Iddo,[e] Zechariah; of
Ginnethon, Meshullam; 17 of Abijah, Zichri; of Miniamin,[f] of Moadiah,
Piltai; 18 of Bilgah, Shammua; of Shemaiah, Jehonathan; 19 of Joiarib,
Mattenai; of Jedaiah, Uzzi; 20 of Sallai, Kallai; of Amok, Eber; 21 of
Hilkiah, Hashabiah; of Jedaiah, Nethanel.
22 As for the Levites in the days of Eliashib, Joiada, Johanan, and
Jaddua, heads of fathers' houses were written down, and the priests

as well, up to the reign of Darius the Persian.[g] 23 The family heads
of the descendants of Levi were recorded in the Book of the Chron-
icles up to the time of Johanan son of Eliashib. 24 The leaders of the
Levites were Hashabiah, Sherebiah, and Jeshua son of Kadmiel, along
with their fellow Levites, who stood opposite them to give praise
and thanks, one group answering the other, as David the man of
God had commanded. 25 Mattaniah, Bakbukiah, Obadiah, Meshullam,
Talmon, and Akkub were gatekeepers who guarded the storerooms
at the gates. 26 These were in the days of Joiakim son of Jeshua, son of
Jozadak, and in the days of Nehemiah the governor and of Ezra the
priest, the scribe.
27 For the dedication of Jerusalem's wall they searched out the Levites
wherever they lived and brought them to Jerusalem to keep the
dedication joyfully, with songs of thanks and with music on cymbals,
harps, and lyres. 28 And the sons of the singers gathered together from
the surrounding district around Jerusalem and from the villages of
the Netophathites, 29 and from Beth-gilgal and the fields of Geba and
Azmaveth, since the singers had made villages for themselves around
Jerusalem. 30 And the priests and the Levites purified themselves, and
they purified the people and the gates and the wall.
31 I had the officials of Judah go up on top of the wall, and I set two
large thanksgiving choirs in procession. One went along the top of
the wall southward,[h] toward the Dung Gate; 32 And after them went
Hoshaiah and half of the leaders of Judah, 33 and Azariah, Ezra,
Meshullam, 34 Judah, Benjamin, Shemaiah, and Jeremiah, 35 and some
of the priests' sons with trumpets: Zechariah son of Jonathan, son of
Shemaiah, son of Mattaniah, son of Micaiah, son of Zaccur, son of
Asaph; 36 and his brothers, Shemaiah, Azarel, Milalai, Gilalai, Maai,
Nethanel, Judah, and Hanani, with the musical instruments of David
the man of God. And Ezra the scribe went before them. 37 At the
Fountain Gate they climbed straight up the steps of the City of David,
on the rising part of the wall above David's palace, and went on to
the Water Gate on the east.
38 The second thanksgiving choir went northward,[i] with me following
and half the people, on top of the wall, beyond the Tower of the

Ovens to the Broad Wall, 39 over the Gate of Ephraim, past the Old Gate,[j] by the Fish Gate and Hananel's Tower and the Tower of the Hundred, to the Sheep Gate; and they took their stand at the Gate of the Guard. 40 So both choirs that gave thanks stood in the house of God, and I and half of the officials with me; 41 and the priests Eliakim, Maaseiah, Miniamin, Micaiah, Elioenai, Zechariah, and Hananiah, with trumpets; 42 and Maaseiah, Shemaiah, Eleazar, Uzzi, Jehohanan, Malchijah, Elam, and Ezer. And the singers sang aloud, with Jezrahiah as their leader. 43 On that day they offered great sacrifices and rejoiced, because God had given them great joy. The women and children rejoiced too, and the sound of Jerusalem's celebration was heard far away.

44 On that day men were appointed over the storerooms for the contributions, the firstfruits, and the tithes. They were to gather into them, from the fields around the towns, the portions required by the Law for the priests and Levites, because the people of Judah were pleased with the priests and Levites who served. 45 They performed the charge of their God and the charge of cleansing, and so did the singers and gatekeepers, as David and Solomon his son had commanded. 46 For in David's day, and Asaph's, long before, there were chiefs[k] over the singers, and songs of praise and thanks to God. 47 And all Israel in the days of Zerubbabel and in the days of Nehemiah gave the portions for the singers and the gatekeepers, as each day required. And they set apart that which was for the Levites, and the Levites set apart that which was for the sons of Aaron.

Notes

- a (12:9) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Unno.
- b (12:9) Or "by watches"; Hebrew "for watches."
- c (12:11) Jaddua was high priest about 330 BC, according to Josephus. The Jonathan of this verse is probably the Johanan of verses 22–23 (see the Elephantine papyri, which name a high priest Johanan about 410 BC).
- d (12:14) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Malluchi. Compare Malluch in verse 2.
- e (12:16) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Iddi.
- f (12:17) A name seems to have dropped out of the Hebrew text here.

- g (12:22) Probably Darius II, king of Persia 423–404 BC, though some think of Darius III (336–330 BC).
- h (12:31) Hebrew "to the right," that is, to the south for one facing east.
- i (12:38) Hebrew "to the front," perhaps "opposite"; the Septuagint and other ancient versions read "to the left," that is, to the north.
- j (12:39) Or "the Jeshanah Gate"; see 3:6.
- k (12:46) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has the singular, "a head."

Chapter 13

1 On that day the Book of Moses was read aloud to the people, and
in it they found it written that an Ammonite or a Moabite must
never come into the assembly of God, 2 because they had not met the
Israelites with food and water, but had hired Balaam to curse them.
Yet our God turned the curse into a blessing.[a] 3 When the people heard
the Law, they set apart from Israel everyone of foreign mixture.
4 Now before this, Eliashib the priest, who was appointed over the
chambers of the house of our God, and who was related to Tobiah,
5 had made ready for him a great room, where before they used to
store the grain offering, the frankincense, and the vessels, with the
tithe of grain, new wine, and oil commanded for the Levites, singers,
and gatekeepers, and the contributions due the priests. 6 I was not in
Jerusalem while all this was happening, because in the thirty-second
year of Artaxerxes king of Babylon[b] I had gone back to the king. Some
time later I asked the king for leave 7 When I came to Jerusalem I
learned of the wrong Eliashib had done for Tobiah in fitting out a
room for him in the courts of God's house. 8 It displeased me deeply,
and I flung all of Tobiah's household goods out of the room. 9 At my
command they purified the rooms, and I put back in them the vessels
of God's house along with the grain offering and the frankincense.
10 I also learned that the Levites had not been given their share, so
that the Levites and singers who did the work had each gone back to
his own farm. 11 I rebuked the officials and asked, "Why has the house
of God been neglected?" Then I gathered the Levites and singers and
restored them to their posts. 12 And all Judah brought in the tithe of
grain, new wine, and oil to the storerooms. 13 Over the storerooms

I put in charge Shelemiah the priest, Zadok the scribe, and Pedaiah from the Levites, with Hanan son of Zaccur, son of Mattaniah, to help them, since they were counted trustworthy; it fell to them to hand out shares to their brothers. 14 Remember me, O my God, concerning this, and do not wipe out my good deeds that I have done for the house of my God and for its services.

15 In those days I saw men in Judah treading the winepresses on the Sabbath, bringing in sheaves and loading donkeys with them, and with wine, grapes, figs, and every sort of burden, bringing them into Jerusalem on the Sabbath day. And I testified against them on the day they sold provisions. 16 Tyrians who lived there also brought in fish and every kind of merchandise and sold it on the Sabbath to the people of Judah, even in Jerusalem. 17 Then I confronted the nobles of Judah and said to them, "What is this evil thing that you are doing, profaning the Sabbath day? 18 Is this not what your fathers did, so that our God brought all this evil on us and on this city? And you add to the wrath on Israel by profaning the Sabbath!"

19 When the gates of Jerusalem grew shadowed before the Sabbath, I gave word and the doors were shut, and I ordered that they not be opened until the Sabbath was over. I set some of my young men over the gates so that no burden would come in on the Sabbath day. 20 The traders and the sellers of all sorts of wares then lodged outside Jerusalem, once and twice. 21 But I warned them and said to them, "Why are you lodging in front of the wall? If you do so again, I will lay hands on you." From that time on they did not come on the Sabbath. 22 And I told the Levites to purify themselves and come to keep the gates, so as to hallow the Sabbath day. For this, too, remember me, my God, and have pity on me as befits your abundant steadfast love.

23 In those days also I saw the Jews who had married women of Ashdod, Ammon, and Moab.[c] 24 Half of their children spoke Ashdodite, and none of them knew how to speak Judean,[d] only the tongue of one people or another. 25 I contended with them and cursed them; I struck some of the men and tore out their hair, and I put them under oath by God: "Do not give your daughters to their sons, and do not take any of their daughters for your sons or yourselves. 26 Didn't Solomon king

of Israel sin because of women like these? Among the many nations there was no king like him. He was loved by his God, and God made him king over all Israel. Yet even he was drawn into sin by foreign women.[e] 27 And must we hear of you doing all this great evil, being faithless to our God by marrying foreign women?" 28 One of the sons of Joiada son of Eliashib the high priest was son-in-law to Sanballat the Horonite, so I drove him away from me. 29 Remember them, O my God, because they have defiled the priesthood and the covenant of the priesthood and the Levites.

30 So I purified them from everything foreign and set up the duties for the priests and the Levites, each man in his task, 31 and I provided for the wood offering at appointed times, and for the firstfruits. Remember me, O my God, for good.

Notes

- a (13:2) See Deuteronomy 23:3–5; Numbers 22–24.
- b (13:6) That is, in 433–432 BC. The Persian king also bore the title king of Babylon.
- c (13:23) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) spells "Ashdodite" and "Ammonite" slightly differently.
- d (13:24) Hebrew "Jewish" (yehudit), the language of Judah, that is, Hebrew; compare 2 Kings 18:26.
- e (13:26) See 1 Kings 11:1–8.

Esther

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 It happened in the days of Ahasuerus[a]—this is the Ahasuerus who
reigned from India as far as Cush,[b] over 127 provinces— 2 in those
days, as King Ahasuerus was seated upon the throne of his kingdom,
which was in Susa the citadel,[c] 3 in the third year of his rule[d] he gave
a banquet for all his officials and attendants. Persia's and Media's
military leaders, the nobles,[e] and the provincial governors were in
his presence, 4 when for many days—180 days[f]—he made a show of
the wealth of his glorious kingdom and the precious splendor of his
greatness.
5 When these days were completed, the king held for all the people
who were found in Susa the citadel, from great to small, a feast of
seven days in the court of the garden of the king's palace. 6 There
were hangings of white cotton and violet, held by cords of fine linen
and purple to silver rings and pillars of marble; couches of gold and
silver stood on a pavement of porphyry, marble, mother-of-pearl, and
costly stone.[g] 7 Drinks were served in vessels of gold, the vessels each
different from the other, and royal wine was plentiful, as befitted the
king's bounty.[h] 8 And the drinking was by rule: no one was compelled,
for so the king had ordered every officer of his household, to do as
each man wished. 9 Queen Vashti[i] also held a feast for the women in
the royal house that belonged to King Ahasuerus.
10 On the seventh day, when the king's heart was merry with wine,
he told Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha and Abagtha, Zethar
and Carkas, the seven eunuchs[j] who served in the presence of King
Ahasuerus, 11 to bring Queen Vashti before the king wearing the royal
crown,[k] to show the peoples and the officials her beauty, for she was
lovely to look at. 12 But Queen Vashti refused to come at the king's

word sent by the eunuchs. Then the king was very angry, and his wrath burned within him.
13 So the king spoke to the wise men who knew the times—for this was
the king's practice before all who knew law and judgment; 14 those
closest to him were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres,
Marsena, and Memucan, the seven princes of Persia and Media, who
saw the king's face and sat first in the kingdom— 15 "According to law,
what must be done to Queen Vashti, since she did not carry out the
order of King Ahasuerus brought by the eunuchs?"
16 Then Memucan[l] said before the king and the princes, "Not against
the king alone has Queen Vashti done wrong, but against all the
princes and all the peoples in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus.
17 For word of what the queen did will reach every woman, so that
they will look with scorn on their husbands, saying, 'King Ahasuerus
ordered Queen Vashti brought into his presence, and she would not
come.' 18 This very day the noble ladies of Persia and Media who have
heard of the queen's deed will speak of it to all the king's princes,
and there will be contempt and wrath enough. 19 If it pleases the king,
let a royal word go out from him and be written among the laws of
Persia and Media, so that it cannot pass away, that Vashti is not to
come before King Ahasuerus again; and let the king give her royal
position to a companion of hers who is better than she. 20 So when
the king's decree that he makes is heard throughout all his kingdom,
vast as it is, all wives will give honor to their husbands, from great
to small."
21 The word pleased the king and the princes, and the king did as
Memucan said. 22 And he dispatched letters to every one of the king's
provinces, each province in its writing and each people in its tongue,
that every man should rule in his household and speak the tongue of
his own people.[m]

Notes

- a (1:1) Ahasuerus is the Hebrew form of the Persian name Khshayarsha, known in Greek as Xerxes; this is Xerxes I, king of Persia 486–465 BC. The Hebrew book of Esther never names God; its story tells of providence without speaking of it. The Greek (Septuagint) form of Esther includes six longer passages, with prayers

and letters, that are not in the Hebrew. This translation follows the Hebrew; those Greek Additions to Esther will be given with the Apocrypha.

- b (1:1) That is, from the Indus valley to the upper Nile (ancient Nubia, modern Sudan).
- c (1:2) Susa (Hebrew Shushan), the winter capital of the Persian kings, in what is now southwestern Iran. "The citadel" is the fortified royal quarter of the city.
- d (1:3) That is, 483 BC.
- e (1:3) Hebrew partemim, a Persian loanword for nobles or men of the first rank.
- f (1:4) About six months.
- g (1:6) The identification of several of these materials is uncertain. Hebrew karpas ("cotton") is a Persian loanword.
- h (1:7) Hebrew "according to the hand of the king."
- i (1:9) Vashti is probably a Persian name meaning "the desired" or "the best." Greek historians name Xerxes' queen as Amestris; the relation of the two is debated.
- j (1:10) Or "officials." Hebrew saris can mean a court officer in general, but in Persian courts it usually meant a eunuch. The names of the eunuchs and princes in this book are Persian.
- k (1:11) Hebrew keter, a turban-like crown, a Persian word found in the Bible only in Esther.
- l (1:16) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has Momucan.
- m (1:22) The meaning of the last clause is uncertain; perhaps that the husband's language was to be spoken in a household of mixed peoples.

Chapter 2

1 Some time later, once King Ahasuerus's fury had cooled, he thought
of Vashti, of what she had done, and of the decision made about her.
2 Then the king's young men who attended him said, "Let young
virgins of fair appearance be sought for the king. 3 Let the king also
name officials throughout his empire to collect every attractive young
virgin into the harem at the citadel of Susa, under the supervision of
Hegai,[a] the king's eunuch who guards the women; and let them be
given beauty treatments. 4 And the girl who is good in the king's eyes,
let her be queen in place of Vashti." The word was good in the king's
eyes, and he did so.
5 There was a Jewish man in Susa the citadel whose name was
Mordecai,[b] son of Jair, son of Shimei, son of Kish, a Benjaminite, 6
who had been carried away from Jerusalem with the exiles taken with
Jeconiah king of Judah, whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had
carried away.[c] 7 He was raising Hadassah,[d] that is, Esther, his uncle's

daughter, because she had lost both parents. The young woman had a lovely figure and a beautiful face, and Mordecai took her in as his own daughter after her father and mother died.

8 So when the king's word and his decree were heard, and when many young women were gathered to Susa the citadel into the custody of Hegai, Esther also was taken into the king's house, into the custody of Hegai, keeper of the women. 9 The girl was good in his eyes and won his favor, and he quickly provided her cosmetics and her portions, and seven chosen young women from the king's house, and he moved her and her young women to the best place in the house of the women. 10 Esther had not revealed her people or her birth, because Mordecai had instructed her that she must not reveal it. 11 Day by day Mordecai would walk up and down before the court of the women's house to find out how Esther fared and what was being done with her.

12 Now when each girl's turn came to go in to King Ahasuerus, after she had been treated under the regulations for the women for twelve months—for so the days of their beautifying were completed: six months with oil of myrrh and six months with spices and the women's cosmetics— 13 then in this way the girl went in to the king: whatever she asked for was given her to take with her from the house of the women to the king's house. 14 She went in at evening, and at dawn she came back to a different women's quarters under the care of Shaashgaz,[e] the king's eunuch who guarded the concubines. She could not return to the king unless he had taken delight in her and called her by name.

15 Now when it came the turn of Esther—daughter of Abihail, Mordecai's uncle, whom Mordecai had taken as a daughter—to go in to the king, she requested nothing beyond what Hegai, the king's eunuch who kept the women, told her. And Esther found favor in the sight of everyone who looked at her. 16 So Esther was taken to King Ahasuerus, into his royal house, in the tenth month, which is the month of Tevet (December–January),[f] in the seventh year of his reign. 17 And the king loved Esther more than all the women, and she won grace and favor before him more than all the virgins, so that he set the royal crown on her head and made her queen in place of Vashti. 18

Then the king gave a huge banquet for all his officials and attendants in honor of Esther. He also proclaimed a tax holiday[g] for the provinces and handed out gifts in keeping with a king's generosity.
19 When the virgins were assembled a second time, Mordecai sat in the gate of the king.[h] 20 Esther had not made known her kindred or her people, just as Mordecai had commanded her, for Esther did what Mordecai said, just as when she was brought up by him.
21 During those days, as Mordecai sat in the gate of the king, two of the king's eunuchs who guarded the threshold, Bigthan and Teresh, grew angry and plotted to strike at King Ahasuerus. 22 Mordecai learned of it and informed Queen Esther, and Esther reported it to the king, giving Mordecai's name as her source. 23 When the matter was investigated and found to be so, the two of them were hanged on a pole.[i] And it was written in the book of the chronicles in the king's presence.

Notes

- a (2:3) Hegai is a Persian name; in verse 8 it is spelled Hege.
- b (2:5) Mordecai is a Babylonian name, related to that of the god Marduk. A Persian official named Marduka appears in tablets from Persepolis of this period.
- c (2:6) That is, in 597 BC (2 Kings 24:10–17). The one carried away may be Kish, Mordecai's great-grandfather, rather than Mordecai himself.
- d (2:7) Hadassah is Hebrew for "myrtle." Esther is probably from the Persian for "star," though some connect it with the Babylonian goddess Ishtar.
- e (2:14) A Persian name.
- f (2:16) That is, at the turn of 479 to 478 BC, four years after Vashti was put aside (1:3).
- g (2:18) Perhaps a remission of taxes, or a holiday.
- h (2:19) That is, he held an office at the royal court; the gate complex was the seat of government business.
- i (2:23) Hebrew "on a tree" or "on wood"; probably impaled or displayed on a stake, the Persian manner of execution. Likewise throughout the book.

Chapter 3

1 After these things King Ahasuerus promoted Haman the son of Hammedatha the Agagite,[a] and lifted him up, and set his seat above all the princes who were with him. 2 And all the king's servants who were at the king's gate would bow down and do homage to Haman,

for the king had so commanded concerning him. But Mordecai would
not bow down or do homage. 3 And the king's servants in the king's
gate asked Mordecai, "Why are you disobeying the order of the
king?" 4 When they had said this[b] to him every day, and he paid them
no heed, they reported it to Haman, to find out whether Mordecai's
claims would hold, for he had let them know he was a Jew. 5 When
Haman noticed that Mordecai would not kneel or bow to him, he was
seething with rage. 6 Yet he scorned to lay a hand on Mordecai by
himself, since they had made known to him Mordecai's people; and
Haman set out to wipe out all the Jews, Mordecai's people, in the
entire realm of Ahasuerus.
7 In the first month, which is the month of Nisan (March–April), in
the twelfth year of King Ahasuerus,[c] they cast Pur[d]—that is, the lot
—before Haman, from day to day and from month to month, to the
twelfth month, which is the month of Adar (February–March).[e]
8 Then Haman said to King Ahasuerus, "There is a certain people
scattered and dispersed among the peoples in all the provinces of
your kingdom. Their laws differ from those of every people, and they
do not keep the king's laws, so it is not worth the king's while to
let them be. 9 If the king approves, let an order be written to destroy
them, and I will pay about 375 tons of silver[f] to the officials in charge,
to be deposited in the royal treasury." 10 So the king took his signet
ring from his hand and gave it to Haman the son of Hammedatha the
Agagite, the adversary of the Jews. 11 And the king said to Haman,
"The silver is given to you, the people also, to do with them as is good
in your eyes."
12 The king's secretaries were summoned on the thirteenth day of the
first month,[g] and an order was written exactly as Haman instructed,
addressed to the king's satraps, to the governors of every province,
and to the officials of every people, in each province's own writing
and each people's own language. It was drafted in King Ahasuerus's
name and stamped with the king's signet ring. 13 Letters were sent by
the hands of couriers to all the king's provinces, to destroy, to kill, and
to annihilate all the Jews, from young to old, children and women, on
one day, the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, which is the month

of Adar (February–March),[h] and to plunder their goods. 14 A copy of the text was to be proclaimed as law in each province and displayed to every people, so that they would be prepared for that day. 15 The couriers went out in haste by the king's word, and the law was given out in Susa the citadel. And the king and Haman sat down to drink, but the city of Susa was in confusion.

Notes

- a (3:1) Haman and Hammedatha are probably Persian names. "Agagite" recalls Agag king of Amalek, the foe of Saul son of Kish (1 Samuel 15); Mordecai is of the line of Kish (2:5).
- b (3:4) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a slightly different form of the same verb.
- c (3:7) That is, 474 BC.
- d (3:7) Pur is a Babylonian (Akkadian) word, puru, "lot." Its plural, Purim, gives the festival its name (9:24–26).
- e (3:7) The Hebrew is brief; the Septuagint adds that the lot fell on the thirteenth day of Adar (see verse 13).
- f (3:9) Hebrew "10,000 talents," about 340 metric tons; a talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms). Herodotus reckons the yearly revenue of the whole Persian empire at about 15,000 talents.
- g (3:12) The thirteenth of Nisan, in March–April, the day before Passover (Leviticus 23:5).
- h (3:13) That is, eleven months later, in 473 BC.

Chapter 4

1 Mordecai knew everything that had been done. He tore his garments, clothed himself in sackcloth and ashes, and went out through the city, crying a great and bitter cry. 2 He came only as far as before the gate of the king, since none might come within the gate of the king dressed in sackcloth. 3 And in every province, wherever the king's word and his law reached, there was great mourning among the Jews, with fasting and weeping and lamenting; many lay in sackcloth and ashes.

4 Esther's maids and eunuchs came and reported it to her, and the queen was in deep distress. She sent clothes for Mordecai to wear in place of his sackcloth, but he refused them. 5 So Esther summoned Hathach,[a] one of the king's eunuchs who had been assigned to serve her, and sent him to Mordecai to find out what was wrong and why.

6 Hathach went out to Mordecai, to the city square before the gate of
the king. 7 And Mordecai told him all that had happened to him, and
the exact sum of silver that Haman had promised to weigh out into
the king's treasuries for the Jews,[b] to destroy them. 8 He also gave him
a copy of the written law that had been given out in Susa for their
destruction, to show it to Esther and explain it to her, and to charge
her to go in to the king to plead with him and make request before
him for her people.
9 Hathach came and told Esther the words of Mordecai. 10 Then Esther
spoke to Hathach and gave him a message for Mordecai: 11 "Every
royal official and every person in the provinces knows that anyone,
man or woman, who approaches the king in the inner court without
an invitation faces a single penalty: death, unless the king extends his
golden scepter to spare that person's life. And I have not been invited
into the king's presence for thirty days." 12 And they told Mordecai
Esther's words.
13 Then Mordecai said to reply to Esther, "Do not imagine in your soul
that in the king's house you will escape, more than all the Jews. 14 If
you hold your peace at such a time as this, relief and rescue will rise
up for the Jews from some other place,[c] while you and your father's
family will be lost. And who knows if you have not reached the throne
for just such a time?"
15 Then Esther said to reply to Mordecai, 16 "Go and assemble all the
Jews to be found in Susa, and fast on my behalf; neither eat nor drink
for three days, night and day. My maids and I will fast in the same
way. Then I will go in to the king, which is not by the law. And if I am
lost, I am lost." 17 So Mordecai went away and did everything Esther
had commanded him.

Notes

- a (4:5) A Persian name.
- b (4:7) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) spells "the Jews" with an extra letter (hayyehudiyyim). The same difference occurs at 8:1, 8:7, 8:13, 9:15, and 9:18.
- c (4:14) Many interpreters, Jewish and Christian, have seen in "another place" a veiled reference to God, whom the book never names.

Chapter 5

1 On the third day Esther put on her royal robes and stood in the
inner court of the king's house, opposite the king's house, while the
king was sitting on his royal throne in the royal house, opposite
the entrance of the house. 2 And when the king saw Queen Esther
standing in the court, she won favor in his eyes, and the king held out
to Esther the golden scepter that was in his hand. Then Esther drew
near and touched the tip of the scepter. 3 The king asked her, "What
is troubling you, Queen Esther? What do you want? Even if it is half
my kingdom, you will have it." 4 Esther said, "If it pleases the king,
let the king and Haman come today to the feast that I have prepared
for him." 5 Then the king said, "Bring Haman quickly, to do as Esther
has said." So the king and Haman came to the feast that Esther had
prepared.
6 While they were drinking wine, the king asked Esther again, "What
is your wish? You will have it. What do you want? Even half the
kingdom will be granted." 7 Then Esther answered and said, "My
petition and my request is this: 8 if the king looks on me with favor,
and if it pleases him to grant my wish and fulfill my request, may
the king and Haman come to a banquet that I will arrange for them;
tomorrow I will tell the king what I want."
9 That day Haman left in high spirits, cheerful of heart. But when he
saw Mordecai at the palace gate, neither standing up nor flinching
in his presence, Haman was seething with anger at Mordecai. 10
Yet Haman held himself in check and went home, and he sent and
brought his friends and Zeresh[a] his wife. 11 And Haman recounted to
them the glory of his riches, the number of his sons, and all the ways
the king had promoted him, and how he had lifted him up above the
princes and the servants of the king. 12 And Haman went on, "Even
Queen Esther brought nobody else besides me with the king to the
feast she had made; and tomorrow, too, I am called to her with the
king. 13 But none of this satisfies me, as long as I keep seeing Mordecai
the Jew seated in the gate of the king." 14 Then Zeresh his wife and all
his friends said to him, "Let a pole be made, 75 feet[b] high, and in the
morning speak to the king, and let them hang Mordecai on it. Then

go in merrily with the king to the feast." The word pleased Haman, and he had the pole made.

Notes

- a (5:10) A Persian name.
- b (5:14) Hebrew "fifty cubits," about 23 meters.

Chapter 6

1 On that night the king's sleep fled, and he ordered the book of memorable deeds, the chronicles, to be brought, and they were read before the king. 2 There it was found written that Mordecai had reported on Bigthana and Teresh, two eunuchs of the king who guarded the threshold, who had plotted to strike at King Ahasuerus. 3 The king asked, "What reward or recognition did Mordecai receive for this?" The king's attendants answered, "Nothing has been done for him." 4 The king said, "Who is out in the courtyard?" At that moment Haman was walking into the palace's outer courtyard to ask the king whether Mordecai could be hanged on the stake he had set up for him. 5 And the king's young men said to him, "Look, Haman is standing in the court." And the king said, "Let him come in." 6 So Haman entered, and the king put this question to him: "What is the right treatment for a man whom the king wishes to honor?" Haman reasoned privately, "Surely he means me. Whom would the king wish to honor more?" 7 And Haman said to the king, "For the man whom the king delights to honor, 8 let royal garments be brought in which the king has been clothed, and a horse on which the king has ridden, with a royal crown set on its head.[a] 9 Then give the robe and horse into the care of one of the king's noblest officials, and have him dress the man the king wishes to honor and parade him on the horse through the city square, shouting before him, 'So the king rewards the man he delights to honor!'" 10 Then the king said to Haman, "Hurry, take the clothing and the horse, as you have said, and do so to Mordecai the Jew who sits at the king's gate. Let nothing fall short of all that you have spoken." 11 So Haman took the robe and the horse, dressed Mordecai, and led him on the horse through the city square, shouting before him, "So the king rewards the man he delights to honor!"

12 Then Mordecai returned to the king's gate. But Haman hurried to
his house, mourning, with his head covered. 13 Haman told his wife
Zeresh and all his friends everything that had happened to him. His
advisers and his wife Zeresh said to him, "If Mordecai, in front of
whom your fall has begun, is of Jewish descent, you cannot defeat
him; you are certain to be ruined before him." 14 They were still talking
with him when the king's eunuchs came and hastily brought Haman
to Esther's feast.

Notes

- a (6:8) Persian reliefs show royal horses with a crested headdress. Or "and on whose head a royal crown has been set," referring to the man.

Chapter 7

1 So the king and Haman came in to drink with Queen Esther. 2 On
that second day, over their wine, the king once more asked Esther,
"What is your wish, Queen Esther? You will have it. What do you
want? Even half the kingdom will be granted." 3 Queen Esther replied,
"If I have won your favor, my king, and if it seems good to you, spare
my life; that is my wish, and spare my people; that is my request. 4 For
I and my people have been sold off for destruction, for slaughter, and
for annihilation. If we had been sold for bondmen and bondwomen,
I would have kept still; such distress would not be worth the king's
trouble."[a] 5 Then King Ahasuerus spoke and said to Queen Esther,
"Who is he, and where is he, whose heart has filled him to do this?"
6 And Esther said, "An adversary and an enemy—this evil Haman!"
Then Haman was terrified before the king and the queen.
7 And the king rose in his wrath from the wine feast and went into
the palace garden, but Haman stayed to beg Queen Esther for his
life, for he saw that evil had been determined against him by the
king. 8 When the king came back from the palace garden to the room
where they had been drinking, Haman had thrown himself onto the
couch where Esther lay. The king exclaimed, "Would he even attack
the queen while I am in the house?" The moment the words left the
king's lips, they covered Haman's face. 9 Then Harbonah, one of the
eunuchs attending the king, said, "There is also the stake Haman built

for Mordecai, the man who spoke up to help the king; it is standing beside Haman's house, 75 feet[b] tall." The king ordered, "Hang him on it." 10 So they hanged Haman on the stake he had built for Mordecai, and the king's fury subsided.

Notes

- a (7:4) Or "for the enemy could not make good the king's loss." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- b (7:9) Hebrew "fifty cubits," about 23 meters.

Chapter 8

1 That same day King Ahasuerus presented Queen Esther with the estate of Haman, the enemy of the Jews.[a] Mordecai was brought before the king, since Esther had revealed how he was related to her. 2 And the king took off his signet ring, which he had taken from Haman, and gave it to Mordecai. And Esther set Mordecai over the house of Haman.

3 And once more Esther spoke before the king; she threw herself at his feet, weeping, and implored him to undo the evil of Haman the Agagite and the scheme he had laid against the Jews. 4 The king stretched the golden scepter toward Esther, and she got up and stood in the king's presence. 5 She said, "If it seems good to the king, and I have found favor with him, and the proposal strikes the king as proper and he is pleased with me, let an order be written to cancel the dispatches Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite, composed to wipe out the Jews throughout the king's provinces. 6 For how can I bear to look on the evil that will befall my people? And how can I bear to look on the destruction of my kindred?"

7 Then King Ahasuerus said to Queen Esther and to Mordecai the Jew, "Look, I have given Esther the house of Haman, and they have hanged him on the pole because he stretched out his hand against the Jews. 8 You yourselves may now write what you think best about the Jews, in the king's name, and stamp it with the king's signet ring, because a decree issued in the king's name and marked with his ring cannot be reversed."

9 Then the king's scribes were summoned, at that time, in the third
month—the month of Sivan (May–June)—on the twenty-third day.[b]
And everything Mordecai ordered was written to the Jews, and to the
satraps, governors, and provincial officials from India to Cush, 127
provinces, each province in its writing and each people in its tongue,
and to the Jews in their own writing and tongue. 10 He wrote in the
name of King Ahasuerus and sealed it with the king's ring, and he
sent letters by the hands of couriers on horseback, riding swift royal
steeds bred from the stud.[c] 11 In them the king granted the Jews in
each city the right to assemble and defend their lives, to destroy, slay,
and wipe out any armed band of a people or province that should
attack them, children and women,[d] and to take their goods as spoil,
12 on one day throughout all the provinces of King Ahasuerus, on
the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, which is the month of Adar
(February–March). 13 A copy of the text was to be proclaimed as law in
each province and displayed to every people, so that the Jews would
be prepared[e] on that day to repay their enemies. 14 So the couriers,
mounted on the swift royal steeds, went out hurried and pressed by
the king's word. And the law was given out in Susa the citadel.
15 And Mordecai went out from the king's presence in royal garments
of violet and white, wearing a great crown of gold and a robe of fine
linen and purple; and the city of Susa cried out with joy. 16 For the
Jews there was light and gladness and joy and honor. 17 In each and
every province and city to which the king's word and his law came,
the Jews had gladness and joy, feasting, and a good day. And many of
the peoples of the land became Jews,[f] because dread of the Jews had
come on them.

Notes

- a (8:1) For the spelling of "Jews" here and in verses 7 and 13, see the note on 4:7.
- b (8:9) That is, about two months after Haman's decree (3:12), in 474 BC.
- c (8:10) The terms for the horses are Persian loanwords whose exact meaning is uncertain.
- d (8:11) The phrase echoes Haman's decree (3:13). Some take "children and women" as the objects of the attack against the Jews rather than of their defense.
- e (8:13) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a variant spelling.

• f (8:17) Or “pretended to be Jews”; the Hebrew verb occurs only here.

Chapter 9

1 In the twelfth month—the month of Adar (February–March)—on the
thirteenth day,[a] when the king’s command and law were due to be
done, the day the foes of the Jews had hoped to overpower them, the
reverse happened: the Jews themselves overpowered their haters. 2 In
their cities in every province of King Ahasuerus the Jews assembled
to strike at those who sought to harm them. Nobody stood against
them, since dread of them had come on every people. 3 All the
officials of the provinces and the satraps and the governors and the
king’s administrators[b] supported the Jews, for the fear of Mordecai
had fallen on them. 4 For Mordecai was great in the king’s house, and
his fame went out through all the provinces; for the man Mordecai
grew greater and greater. 5 The Jews struck down all their foes with
the sword, slaughtering and destroying, and dealt as they willed with
their haters. 6 In Susa the citadel the Jews killed and destroyed 500
men, 7 and Parshandatha and Dalphon and Aspatha[c] 8 and Poratha
and Adalia and Aridatha 9 and Parmashta and Arisai and Aridai and
Vaizatha, 10 the ten sons of Haman the son of Hammedatha, the
adversary of the Jews. They killed them, but they did not lay their
hands on the plunder.

11 On the same day the count of the slain in Susa the citadel came
before the king. 12 The king said to Queen Esther, “In the citadel of
Susa alone the Jews have killed and destroyed five hundred men, as
well as Haman’s ten sons. What have they done in the rest of the
royal provinces! Now what is your wish? It will be granted. What
more do you ask? It will be done.” 13 And Esther said, “If it pleases the
king, let it be granted to the Jews who are in Susa to do tomorrow also
according to today’s law, and let the ten sons of Haman be hanged
on the pole.”[d] 14 So the king commanded that it be done. A law was
given out in Susa, and they hanged the ten sons of Haman. 15 And the
Jews[e] in Susa assembled on the fourteenth of Adar as well and slew
300 men in Susa; but on the spoil they laid no hand.

16 The other Jews in the king's provinces assembled and defended their
lives and had rest from their foes; they slew 75,000[f] of their haters,
but on the spoil they laid no hand. 17 This was on the thirteenth day
of the month of Adar; and on its fourteenth day they rested and
made it a day of feasting and gladness. 18 But the Jews who were in
Susa gathered on its thirteenth day and on its fourteenth, and on its
fifteenth day they rested and made it a day of feasting and gladness.
19 That is why the Jews of the villages, who live in the rural towns,[g]
keep the fourteenth day of the month of Adar as a day of gladness
and feasting, a holiday, and a day of sending portions to one another.
20 And Mordecai wrote these things down and sent letters to all the
Jews who were in all the provinces of King Ahasuerus, near and far, 21
to establish among them that they should keep the fourteenth day of
the month of Adar and its fifteenth day,[h] year by year, 22 as the days
when the Jews found relief from their enemies, and as the month
when their grief was turned to joy and their mourning to a holiday;
they were to observe them as days of banqueting and joy, exchanging
gifts of food and giving presents to the needy. 23 So the Jews accepted
what they had begun to do and what Mordecai had written to them. 24
For Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite, who persecuted all the
Jews, had planned to destroy the Jews and had thrown the Pur, that
is, the lot, to crush[i] and destroy them. 25 But when it[j] came before the
king, he commanded by letter that his evil plot which he had devised
against the Jews should return on his own head, and that he and his
sons should be hanged on the pole. 26 Therefore they called these days
Purim, after the name of Pur.[k] Therefore, because of all the words of
this letter, and of what they had seen concerning this and what had
come upon them, 27 the Jews established and took on themselves[l] and
on their offspring and on all who joined them, so that it should not
pass away, that they would keep these two days according to what
was written and at their appointed time, year by year; 28 and that these
days should be remembered and kept in every generation, by every
family, every province, and every city, and that these days of Purim
should not pass away from among the Jews, nor the memory of them
cease from their offspring.

29 And Queen Esther, Abihail's daughter, with Mordecai the Jew, wrote
with all authority to make this second Purim letter binding. 30 And
letters were sent to all the Jews, to the 127 provinces of the kingdom
of Ahasuerus, words of peace and truth, 31 to make these days of Purim
binding at their set times, as Mordecai the Jew and Queen Esther had
made them binding on them, and as they had bound themselves and
their descendants concerning their fasts and their cry of lament.[m] 32
The command of Esther confirmed these matters of Purim, and it was
written in the book.

Notes

- a (9:1) In 473 BC.
- b (9:3) Hebrew "those who do the work that belongs to the king."
- c (9:7) The names of the ten sons of Haman in verses 7–9 are Persian. In Hebrew scrolls of Esther they are traditionally written in a column, each name on its own line, and they are read in one breath at the Purim reading.
- d (9:13) That is, their bodies were to be displayed publicly.
- e (9:15) For the spelling of "Jews" here and in verse 18, see the note on 4:7.
- f (9:16) The Septuagint has 15,000.
- g (9:19) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has a variant form of the word. To this day, Purim is kept on the 14th of Adar, but on the 15th ("Shushan Purim") in Jerusalem and other anciently walled cities.
- h (9:21) In the modern calendar these days fall in February or March.
- i (9:24) Or "to throw them into panic."
- j (9:25) Or "she," that is, Esther.
- k (9:26) Purim means "lots," the plural of pur (see 3:7). The festival falls on 14–15 Adar, in February or March.
- l (9:27) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) has the singular, "and he took on himself."
- m (9:31) The fast of Esther is kept on 13 Adar, the day before Purim.

Chapter 10

1 King Ahasuerus[a] laid tribute on the land and on the coastlands of the
sea. 2 And all the acts of his power and his might, and the full account
of the greatness of Mordecai, to which the king raised him, are they
not written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Media and
Persia? 3 For Mordecai the Jew was second to King Ahasuerus, and
great among the Jews, and pleasing to the multitude of his brothers.
He sought the good of his people and spoke peace to all his offspring.

Notes

- a (10:1) So the traditional reading (qere); the written text (ketiv) spells the name without one of its letters.

Job

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the land of Uz[a] there lived a man named Job.[b] He was blameless
and upright, a man who revered God and kept away from evil. 2 There
were born to him seven sons and three daughters. 3 His livestock was
seven thousand sheep, three thousand camels, five hundred yoke of
oxen, and five hundred female donkeys, and a very great body of
servants; so that this man was greater than all the sons of the east.[c] 4
It was the custom of his sons to go and make a feast, each at his own
house on his own day; and they would send and call their three sisters
to eat and drink along with them. 5 When each round of feasting
ended, Job would send for his children and set them apart. Early in
the morning he would offer burnt offerings for every one of them, for
Job thought, "Perhaps my children have sinned and cursed[d] God in
their hearts." This was Job's regular practice.
6 Now there was a day when the sons of God[e] came to present them-
selves before Yahweh, and the Adversary[f] also came among them. 7
Yahweh said to the Adversary, "From where do you come?" Then the
Adversary answered Yahweh and said, "From roaming through the
earth and from walking to and fro in it." 8 And Yahweh said to the
Adversary, "Have you set your heart upon my servant Job, that there
is none like him in the earth, a man blameless and upright, one who
fears God and turns aside from evil?" 9 Then the Adversary answered
Yahweh and said, "Is it for nothing that Job fears God? 10 Have you
not hedged him about, and his house, and all that he has, on every
side? The work of his hands you have blessed, and his livestock has
burst out in the land. 11 But stretch out your hand now and touch all
that he has, and surely he will bless[g] you to your face." 12 Yahweh said
to the Adversary, "Very well: all that he has is under your control.

But you must not harm Job himself." So the Adversary left Yahweh's presence.

13 Now there was a day when his sons and his daughters were eating
and drinking wine in the house of their brother the firstborn, 14 and
a messenger came to Job and said, "The oxen were plowing and the
donkeys grazing beside them, 15 and Sabeans[h] fell upon them and took
them, and the servants they struck with the edge of the sword; and I
alone, only I, have escaped to tell you." 16 He was still speaking when
another messenger arrived and reported, "Fire from God[i] dropped
out of the sky, burning the sheep and servants and consuming them.
Only I got away to bring you the news." 17 He was still speaking when
another came and reported, "Chaldean raiders in three bands charged
the camels and took them. They struck down the servants with their
swords. Only I got away to bring you the news." 18 While he was yet
speaking, another came and said, "Your sons and your daughters were
eating and drinking wine in the house of their brother the firstborn, 19
A mighty wind blew in from across the desert and hit all four corners
of the house. It collapsed on the young people, and they are dead. I
am the only one who escaped to tell you."

20 Then Job got up, tore his robe, and shaved his head. He threw
himself on the ground and worshiped.

21 And he said,

"Naked I came out of my mother's womb,
and naked shall I return there.[j]
Yahweh gave, and Yahweh has taken;
let the name of Yahweh be blessed."

22 Through all of this Job sinned not, nor did he lay anything unseem-
ly[k] to God's charge.

Notes

- a (1:1) The location of Uz is uncertain; it was probably east or southeast of Israel, in or near Edom (compare Lamentations 4:21). The Septuagint's ending (see the note at 42:17) places it "on the borders of Idumea and Arabia" (Brenton).
- b (1:1) The meaning of the name Job (Hebrew ʾIyyov) is uncertain; proposals include "Where is the father?" and "one who is hostile."
- c (1:3) That is, the peoples east of Israel, in the Syrian and Arabian desert.

- d (1:5) Hebrew "blessed," used here and in 1:11, 2:5, and 2:9 as a euphemism for "cursed"; scribes apparently avoided writing "curse God."
- e (1:6) Hebrew bene ha-ʾelohim, heavenly beings of the divine court; so also 2:1 and 38:7. The Septuagint reads "the angels of God" (Brenton).
- f (1:6) Hebrew ha-satan, "the satan," that is, "the adversary" or "the accuser." With the article it is a title or role in the heavenly court, not yet a personal name; so throughout chapters 1–2. The Septuagint reads "the devil" (Brenton).
- g (1:11) Hebrew "bless"; see the note at 1:5.
- h (1:15) The Sabeans were probably raiders from Sheba in southern Arabia; the Septuagint reads "the spoilers" (Brenton).
- i (1:16) Or "a terrible fire," probably lightning.
- j (1:21) That is, to the earth, pictured as the mother of all (compare Psalm 139:15), or to the grave.
- k (1:22) Or "nor did he charge God with wrongdoing"; Hebrew tiflah, "unseemliness."

Chapter 2

1 Again there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before Yahweh, and the Adversary also came among them to present himself before Yahweh. 2 And Yahweh said to the Adversary, "From where do you come?" Then the Adversary answered Yahweh and said, "From roaming through the earth and from walking to and fro in it." 3 Yahweh said to the Adversary, "Have you set your heart upon my servant Job, that there is none like him in the earth, a man blameless and upright, one who fears God and turns aside from evil? And he still holds fast his integrity, although you incited me against him to swallow him up for no cause." 4 Then the Adversary answered Yahweh and said, "Skin for skin![a] All that a man has he will give for his life. 5 But stretch out your hand now and touch his bone and his flesh, and surely he will bless[b] you to your face." 6 And Yahweh said to the Adversary, "Look, he is in your hand; only spare his life."

7 So the Adversary went out from the presence of Yahweh and struck Job with grievous sores[c] from the sole of his foot to his crown. 8 And he took for himself a potsherd to scrape himself with, while he sat in the midst of the ashes.[d]

9 Then his wife said to him, "Do you still hold fast your integrity? Bless[e] God, and die."[f] 10 But he said to her, "You speak as one of the foolish women speaks. Shall we indeed receive the good from God,

and the evil we shall not receive?" In all this Job did not sin with his lips.

11 When Job's three friends heard about all the trouble that had come on him, each one set out from his own home: Eliphaz from Teman, Bildad from Shuah, and Zophar from Naamah.[g] They agreed together to go and offer him sympathy and comfort. 12 And when they lifted up their eyes from afar and did not recognize him, they lifted up their voices and wept; and they tore each his robe and sprinkled dust upon their heads toward the heavens. 13 And they sat with him upon the ground seven days and seven nights, and none spoke a word to him, for they saw that his pain was very great.

Notes

- a (2:4) Probably a proverb from barter: a man will give up one hide to save another, or any possession to save his own skin. The exact sense is uncertain.
- b (2:5) Hebrew "bless"; see the note at 1:5.
- c (2:7) Hebrew shekhin ra'; perhaps boils or a skin disease; the exact illness cannot be identified.
- d (2:8) The Septuagint reads "and sat upon a dung-heap outside the city" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (2:9) Hebrew "bless"; see the note at 1:5.
- f (2:9) The Septuagint has a much longer speech here, in which Job's wife laments their lost children and her own wandering "from place to place and house to house," ending "but say some word against the Lord, and die" (Brenton, modernized).
- g (2:11) Eliphaz perhaps means "God is fine gold" (uncertain); Teman was a region of Edom. Bildad perhaps means "Bel has loved" or "son of Hadad" (uncertain); Shuah was a son of Abraham and Keturah (Genesis 25:2). Zophar perhaps means "sparrow" or "twitterer" (uncertain); Naamah's location is unknown. The Septuagint calls them "Eliphaz the king of the Temanites, Bildad sovereign of the Shuhites, Zophar king of the Minaeans" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 3

1 After this Job opened his mouth and cursed his day. 2 And Job answered and said:

3 "Perish the day wherein I was to be born,
  and the night which said, 'A male has been conceived!'
4 That day—let it be darkness!
  Let not God above seek after it,
  nor light shine upon it.

5 Let darkness and deep shadow[a] claim it as their own;
let a cloud settle upon it;
let the blackenings of the day[b] terrify it.
6 As for that night, let deep darkness take it!
May it not be counted among the days of the year
or enter into the tally of the months.
7 Look, let that night be barren;
let no shout of joy come into it.
8 Let those who curse the day lay a curse on it,
those who are skilled to rouse up Leviathan.[c]
9 Let the stars of its twilight be dark;
let it wait for light, but have none,
nor let it see the eyelids of the dawn,
10 because it did not shut the doors of my mother's womb,
nor hide trouble from my eyes.
11 "Why did I not die from the womb,
come out from the belly and breathe my last?
12 Why did knees receive me?
And why breasts, that I should suck?
13 For by now I would be lying down at rest;
I would be asleep; it would be repose for me,
14 with kings and counselors of the earth,
who rebuilt ruins[d] for themselves,
15 or with princes who had gold,
who filled their houses with silver.
16 Or like a hidden stillbirth I would not be,
like infants who never saw light.
17 There the wicked cease from troubling,
and there the weary in strength are at rest.
18 Together the prisoners are at ease;
they hear not the voice of the taskmaster.
19 The small and the great are there,
and the slave is free from his master.

20 “Why is light given to him who is in misery,
and life to the bitter of soul,
21 They long for death, but it does not come;
they dig for it more eagerly than for buried treasure,
22 who rejoice to exultation
and are glad when they find a grave?
23 Why is light given to a man whose way is hidden,
whom God has hedged in?
24 For my sighing comes before my bread,[e]
and my groanings are poured out like water.
25 For the thing I feared has come upon me,
and what I dreaded comes to me.
26 I am not at ease, nor am I quiet,
nor have I rest; but turmoil comes.”

Notes

- a (3:5) Hebrew tsalmawet, traditionally “shadow of death”; many scholars read it as tsalmut, “deep darkness.” So throughout Job.
- b (3:5) Hebrew kimrire yom, a rare word; perhaps eclipses or the darkenings of the day, or “bitterness of the day” (uncertain).
- c (3:8) Leviathan is a sea monster of ancient Near Eastern myth, a symbol of chaos (compare 41:1; Psalm 74:14; Isaiah 27:1). Some scholars, by a slight change, read “those who curse the sea (yam).” The Septuagint reads “he that is ready to attack the great sea monster” (Brenton, modernized: “the great whale”).
- d (3:14) Or “built tombs” (perhaps pyramids); the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads “who gloried in their swords” (Brenton).
- e (3:24) Or “in place of my bread,” or “at the sight of my food.”

Chapter 4

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said:
2 “If one ventures a word to you, will you be wearied?
Yet who can hold back from speaking?
3 Look, you have instructed many,
and slack hands you have made strong.
4 The one who was stumbling your words have lifted up,
and knees that bowed you have made firm.
5 But now it has come to you, and you are wearied;
it touches you, and you are dismayed.

6 Is not your fear of God your confidence,
and your hope the blamelessness of your ways?
7 “Recall, I beg you: what guiltless man has perished?
And where have upright men been cut off?
8 Even as I have observed: plowers of wickedness,
and sowers of mischief—the same they harvest.
9 By the breath of God they perish,
and by the blast of his anger they are consumed.
10 The roar of the lion and the voice of the fierce lion,
and the teeth of the young lions—they are broken.[a]
11 The old lion perishes for want of prey,
and the cubs of the lioness are scattered.
12 “Now to me a word came stealing,
and my ear received a whisper of it.
13 Amid disquieting thoughts from visions of the night,
when deep sleep falls upon men,
14 dread came upon me, and trembling,
and the multitude of my bones it made to shake.
15 Then a spirit[b] glided past my face;
the hair of my flesh stood on end.
16 It stood there, yet I could not make out its shape.
A form was in front of my eyes,
and in the stillness I heard a voice:
17 ‘Shall mortal man be just in the sight of God?[c]
Or shall a man be clean in the sight of the one who made him?
18 Look, in his servants he puts no trust,
and to his angels he charges error.[d]
19 How much more those who dwell in houses of clay,
whose foundation is in the dust,
who are crushed sooner than the moth!
20 Between morning and evening they are beaten to pieces;
without anyone heeding, they perish forever.
21 Is not their tent-cord[e] pulled up within them?
They die, and not in wisdom.’

Notes

- a (4:10) Five different Hebrew words for lion appear in 4:10–11 (ʾaryeh, shaḥal, kefir, layish, and lavi); their exact distinctions are uncertain.
- b (4:15) Or "a wind" or "a breath."
- c (4:17) Hebrew Eloah, a poetic singular of Elohim; it occurs about forty times in Job and is translated "God." Or "more righteous than God … more pure than his Maker."
- d (4:18) Hebrew toholah, found only here (a hapax legomenon); the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "error" or "folly."
- e (4:21) Or "their excellence"; the Hebrew yeter can mean a tent-cord or what is left over.

Chapter 5

1 "Cry out, then! Is there one to answer you?
To which among the holy ones[a] would you turn?
2 Surely resentment slays the foolish,
and envy puts the gullible to death.
3 With my own eyes I saw a fool striking root,
and at once I pronounced his homestead cursed.
4 His sons are far from safety;
they are crushed in the gate, and there is none to deliver.
5 His harvest the hungry eat up,
and even from among thorns they take it,[b]
and the thirsty[c] pant after their wealth.
6 For mischief springs not up out of the dust,
nor from the soil does misery sprout;
7 but man is born to trouble,
as the sons of Resheph[d] fly upward.
8 "But I—I would inquire of God,
and before God I would lay my case,
9 who does great things beyond searching out,
wonders without number;
10 who gives rain upon the face of the earth
and sends waters upon the face of the fields;
11 to set the lowly up on high,
and mourners are raised to safety.

12 He frustrates the plans of the crafty,
so that their hands achieve nothing lasting.[e]
13 He takes the wise in their own craftiness,[f]
and the counsel of the twisted is swept headlong.
14 By day they meet with darkness,
and at noon they grope as in the night.
15 He rescues the needy from the sword in their mouth
and from the grip of the powerful.
16 So the poor has hope,
and injustice shuts her mouth.
17 "Happy is the one whom God corrects!
So do not despise the instruction of Shaddai.[g]
18 For he wounds, but he binds up;
he smites, and his hands heal.
19 In six troubles he will deliver you,
and in seven no evil shall touch you.
20 In famine he redeems you from death,
and in war from the hand of the sword.
21 You will be sheltered from the lash of the tongue,
and you will have no fear when destruction comes.
22 At destruction and at hunger you shall laugh,
and of the beasts of the earth you shall not be afraid.
23 For with the stones of the field you shall be in covenant,
and the beasts of the field shall be at peace with you.
24 You shall know your tent to be in peace;
you shall visit your pasture-place and find nothing gone astray.
25 You shall know your seed to be numerous,
your offspring as the herbage of the ground.
26 You shall come to the grave in ripe old age,[h]
as a sheaf goes up in its season.
27 Look, this we have searched out; so it is.
Hear it, and know it for yourself."

Notes

- a (5:1) That is, heavenly beings.
- b (5:5) The Hebrew of this line is obscure.

- c (5:5) So several ancient versions (Aquila, Symmachus, the Syriac, and the Vulgate, reading tseme'im); the Hebrew word tsammim is uncertain, often taken as "a snare."
- d (5:7) Resheph was a Canaanite god of plague and fire; "the sons of Resheph" may be sparks or birds of prey. Or "as sparks fly upward." The Septuagint reads "the vulture's young seek the high places" (Brenton).
- e (5:12) Hebrew tushiyyah, a word of uncertain meaning found mostly in Job and Proverbs: "success," "sound wisdom," or "lasting result."
- f (5:13) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 3:19.
- g (5:17) Hebrew Shaddai, a divine name traditionally rendered "the Almighty"; its meaning is uncertain (see the note at Genesis 17:1). It occurs 31 times in Job and is kept as a name throughout.
- h (5:26) Hebrew kelaḥ, found only here and in 30:2; the meaning "full vigor" or "ripe age" is a guess from context.

Chapter 6

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "O that my vexation were but weighed,
and my calamity laid with it in the balances!
3 For now it would be heavier than the sand of the seas;
therefore my words have been rash.[a]
4 The arrows of Shaddai are lodged in me,
and my spirit drinks in their poison;
God's terrors are lined up against me.
5 Does the wild donkey bray over the grass,
or does the ox low over its fodder?
6 Can what is tasteless be eaten without salt,
or is there any flavor in the slime of the purslane?[b]
7 My soul refuses to touch them;
they are like sickness in my food.[c]
8 "O that my request might come,
and that God would grant my hope,
9 that it would please God to crush me,
that he would let loose his hand and cut me off!
10 Then this would still be my comfort,
and I would leap for joy[d] in pain that does not spare,
that I have not hidden the words of the Holy One.

11 What is my strength, that I should wait?
And what is my end, that I should prolong my life?
12 Is my strength the strength of stones,
or is my flesh bronze?
13 Is not my help within me gone,
and sound wisdom[e] driven away from me?
14 "To one who is fainting, kindness is owed from his friend,
even if he forsakes the fear of Shaddai.[f]
15 My brothers have dealt deceitfully like a wadi,
like the channels of wadis that pass away,
16 which are dark with ice,
where the snow hides itself;
17 at the time they are scorched, they vanish;
when it is hot, they are extinguished from their place.
18 Caravans swerve from off their way;
up into the empty waste they go, and perish.
19 The caravans out of Tema have looked for them;
on them the companies of Sheba set their hope.
20 They are ashamed because they trusted;
they come there and are confounded.
21 For now you have become nothing;[g]
you see a terror, and are afraid.
22 Did I say, 'Give to me,'
or, 'From your wealth offer a bribe for me,'
23 or, 'Deliver me from the hand of the foe,'
and, 'From the hand of the ruthless ransom me'?
24 "Teach me, and I will be silent;
and make me understand how I have erred.
25 How forceful are upright words!
But what does your reproving reprove?
26 Do you intend to reprove words,
while the speeches of one in despair are for the wind?
27 Over an orphan you would even throw the lot,
and over your companion you would haggle.

28 But now, be pleased to look at me;
for to your faces I will surely not lie.
29 Turn back, I pray; let there be no injustice;
turn back again; my righteousness is still in it.
30 Is there injustice on my tongue?
Can my palate not discern calamities?

Notes

- a (6:3) Hebrew laʿu, a rare verb; perhaps "wild" or "stammering."
- b (6:6) Hebrew ḥallamut, found only here; perhaps the juice of a mallow or purslane plant, or the white of an egg (so the Targum and many interpreters). The identification is uncertain.
- c (6:7) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- d (6:10) Hebrew saledah, found only here; the meaning "leap" or "exult" is uncertain (perhaps "recoil").
- e (6:13) Hebrew tushiyyah; see the note at 5:12.
- f (6:14) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- g (6:21) The Hebrew is difficult: the written text has lo, "not," and the scribal reading is lo, "to it." Many read "For now you have become like it," that is, like the dried-up wadi. The Septuagint reads "But you also have come to me without pity" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 7

1 "Has not man a time of hard service upon earth,
and are not his days like the days of a hired laborer?
2 As a servant pants for shade,
as a hireling looks for the pay of his work,
3 so I have been allotted months of emptiness,
and nights of trouble have been appointed to me.
4 When I lie down I say, 'At what hour may I rise?'
But the evening drags on,[a]
and I am glutted with restless turnings till the twilight of dawn.
5 My flesh is clothed with worms and clods of dust;
my skin hardens and then runs again.
6 Swifter are my days than the shuttle of a weaver,
and they are spent with no hope remaining.[b]
7 "Remember that my life is a breath;
my eye will not again see good.

8 The eye that sees me now will not see me again;
you will search for me, and I will not be here.
9 As a cloud fades and goes away,
so he who goes down to Sheol[c] does not come up.
10 He shall not return again to his house,
nor shall his place know him anymore.
11 "Therefore I also will not restrain my mouth;
I will speak in the distress of my spirit;
I will complain in the bitterness of my soul.
12 Am I Sea, or am I Dragon,[d]
that over me you post a watch?
13 When I say, 'My bed will comfort me,
my couch will ease my complaint,'
14 then you terrify me with dreams
and affright me with visions,
15 so that my soul would choose strangling,
death rather than these bones of mine.
16 I loathe it; I would not live forever.
Leave me alone, for my days are a breath.
17 "What is man, that you should make so much of him,
and that you should set your heart upon him,
18 and visit him every morning,
and test him every moment?
19 How long will you not look away from me,
nor let me alone till I swallow my spittle?
20 If I have sinned, how have I harmed you,
you who watch over humanity?
Why have you made me your target?
Why have I become a weight to myself?[e]
21 And why do you not pardon my transgression
and take away my iniquity?
For now I shall lie down in the dust;
and you will seek me diligently, but I shall not be."

Notes

- a (7:4) Hebrew middad, uncertain; perhaps "the evening stretches out."
- b (7:6) Hebrew tiqwah, "hope," also means "thread" or "cord" (Joshua 2:18); a wordplay with the weaver's shuttle.
- c (7:9) Sheol is the Hebrew name for the realm of the dead.
- d (7:12) Hebrew tannin, a sea dragon of ancient myth; compare 3:8.
- e (7:20) So the standard Hebrew text; an ancient scribal tradition (one of the "corrections of the scribes") and the Septuagint read "a burden to you" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 8

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered and said:
2 "How long will you go on talking like this?
  Your words are a blustering wind.
3 Does God pervert justice,
  or does Shaddai pervert what is right?
4 If your sons have sinned against him,
  he has sent them away into the hand of their transgression.
5 If you yourself will seek God earnestly
  and make supplication to Shaddai,
6 if you are pure and honest,
  he will surely rise up on your behalf
  and restore your rightful home.
7 And though your beginning was small,
  your latter end would grow very great.
8 "For ask, I pray, of the former generation,
  and set yourself to what their fathers searched out.
9 For we are of yesterday and know nothing,
  because our days upon earth are a shadow.
10 Shall not they instruct you, speak to you,
  and from out of their heart bring forth words?
11 Does the papyrus[a] rise up without a swamp?
  Does the rush grow tall without water?
12 While it is yet in its green shoot, not cut down,
  before any other grass it withers.
13 Such is the fate of everyone who forgets God;
  the hope of the godless comes to nothing.

14 His confidence is cut off,[b]
and his trust is a spider's house.[c]
15 He leans upon his house, but it does not stand;
he grasps hold of it, but it does not endure.
16 He is a well-watered plant before the sun,
and over his garden his shoots go forth.
17 Over a heap of stones his roots are entwined;
he gazes upon a house of stones.[d]
18 If he is swallowed up from his place,
then it will deny him: 'I never saw you.'
19 Look, this is the joy of his way,[e]
and from the dust others will spring up.
20 "See, God spurns not the man of integrity,
nor does he grasp the hand of doers of evil.
21 Yet once more he will fill your mouth with laughing,
and your lips with a joyful shout.
22 Those who hate you shall be clothed with shame,
and the tent of the wicked shall be no more."

Notes

- a (8:11) Hebrew gome', the papyrus plant of the Nile marshes.
- b (8:14) Hebrew yaqot, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "is a gossamer thread" or "is cut off."
- c (8:14) That is, a spider's web.
- d (8:17) Or "he lives among stones"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (8:19) That is, ironically, this is how his "joy" ends.

Chapter 9

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "Truly I know that it is so;
but how can a man be in the right with God?
3 Should one desire to go to law with him,
not once in a thousand times could he reply to him.
4 He is wise in heart and mighty in strength;
who has hardened himself against him and been unharmed?
5 He shifts mountains before they realize it,
and in his anger he turns them over.

6 who shakes the earth out of its place,
and its pillars tremble;
7 who speaks to the sun, and it does not rise,
and sets a seal upon the stars;
8 who alone stretches out the heavens
and treads upon the heights[a] of the sea;
9 who made the Bear, Orion, and the Pleiades,[b]
and the chambers of the south;
10 who does great things beyond searching out,
and wonders without number.
11 He goes by beside me, and I behold him not;
he sweeps on, and I have no perception of him.
12 He seizes, and who can make him give it back?
Who shall say to him, 'What is this you do?'
13 "God turns not back his wrath;
under him the allies of Rahab[c] lay bowed.
14 How much less shall I answer him,
choosing my words with him?
15 Though I were in the right, I could not answer;
to my judge I would have to plead for mercy.
16 Should I call and he answer me,
I could not trust that my voice had his ear.
17 For he crushes me with a tempest
and multiplies my wounds without cause.
18 He does not allow me to draw my breath again,
but sates me with bitter things.
19 If it is a matter of strength, look, he is mighty!
And if of justice, who will summon me?[d]
20 Were I in the right, my mouth itself would declare me guilty;
were I without blame, it would show me crooked.
21 I am blameless; I do not regard myself;
I loathe my life.
22 It is all one; therefore I say,
'The blameless and the wicked he brings to an end.'

23 When a scourge kills suddenly,
he mocks at the despair of the innocent.
24 The earth is given into the hand of the wicked;
the faces of its judges he covers.
If it is not he, then who is it?
25 "My days are swifter than a runner;
they flee away; they see no good.
26 They have slipped by like boats of reed,[e]
like an eagle that swoops upon its food.
27 If I say, 'I will forget my complaint,
I will put off my sad face and be cheerful,'
28 I shrink in fear from all my pains;
I know you will not count me guiltless.
29 I shall be condemned;
why then do I labor in vain?
30 If I wash myself with snow
and cleanse my hands with lye,[f]
31 even then into the ditch you would dip me,
and my garments would find me loathsome.
32 For he is not a human being like me, that I could answer him,
that the two of us could go to court together.
33 Between us no umpire[g] stands,
to rest his hand upon the two of us.
34 Let him take his rod away from me,
and let not dread of him terrify me.
35 Then I would speak and not fear him;
for I am not so in myself.

Notes

- a (9:8) Hebrew "the backs" (bamote), which may mean the waves or the back of the sea monster; compare 3:8.
- b (9:9) The identification of these constellations (Hebrew 'ash, kesil, and kimah) is uncertain; compare 38:31–32 and Amos 5:8. The Septuagint reads "the Pleiades, and Hesperus, and Arcturus" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (9:13) Rahab is a mythic sea monster representing chaos (compare 26:12; Psalm 89:10; Isaiah 51:9), not the woman of Jericho; the names are spelled differently

in Hebrew. The Septuagint reads "the sea monsters under heaven" (Brenton, modernized: "the whales").

- d (9:19) The Hebrew may be quoting God's reply; many read "who can summon him?" The Septuagint reads "who then shall resist his judgment?" (Brenton). The line is uncertain.
- e (9:26) Light boats made of papyrus reeds (Isaiah 18:2).
- f (9:30) Hebrew bor, a cleansing agent made from plant ash.
- g (9:33) Or "umpire" or "mediator"; Hebrew mokiaḥ. Some Hebrew manuscripts read "O that there were an arbiter between us"; compare the Septuagint, "Would that our mediator were present" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 10

1 "My soul is weary of my life;
I will give free course to my complaint;
I will speak in the bitterness of my soul.
2 I will say to God, 'Do not condemn me;
make me know why you contend with me.
3 Is it good to you that you oppress,
that you despise the toil of your hands
and shine upon the counsel of the wicked?
4 Have you eyes of flesh,
or do you see as a man sees?
5 Are your days like a mortal's days,
or your years like those of a human being,
6 that you seek after my iniquity
and search for my sin,
7 knowing as you do that I am not in the wrong,
and that from your hand no one can rescue?
8 " 'Your hands shaped me and made me,
all of me round about; yet you would swallow me up?
9 Remember, I pray, that you made me like clay;
and to the dust will you return me?
10 Did you not pour me out like milk
and curdle me like cheese?
11 With skin and flesh you clothed me,
and with bones and sinews you knit me together.

12 Life and steadfast love you have granted me,
and your care has watched over my spirit.
13 Yet these things you kept concealed in your heart;
I am aware that this was your intent:
14 if I sinned, you would watch me
and would not acquit me of my iniquity.
15 If I am guilty, I am doomed!
Even if I am innocent, I dare not raise my head,
filled as I am with shame and drenched in misery.
16 And should it lift itself up, like a lion you would hunt me,
and again you would show yourself wonderful against me.
17 You renew your witnesses against me
and increase your vexation toward me;
changes and a host are with me.[a]
18 " 'Why then did you bring me out from the womb?
I would have breathed my last, and no eye would have seen me.
19 I would have been as though I had not been,
carried from the belly to the grave.
20 Are not my days few? Then cease,[b]
and let me alone, that I may brighten a little,
21 before I go, and return not,
to the land of darkness and deep shadow,
22 a land of gloom like thick darkness,[c]
of deep shadow without any order,
where the light is as thick darkness.' "

Notes

- a (10:17) Or "relays of troops come against me"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- b (10:20) So the written Hebrew text; the scribal reading is "Cease, then, and set me alone."
- c (10:22) Hebrew ʿefatah, a rare word for deep darkness.

Chapter 11

1 Then Zophar the Naamathite answered and said:
2 "Shall a multitude of words go unanswered,
and shall a man of lips[a] be counted in the right?

3 Shall your babble make men hold their peace,
and shall you mock with none to put you to shame?
4 For you say, ‘Spotless is my doctrine,
and in your sight I am pure.’
5 But O that God would speak,
and open his lips against you,
6 and declare to you the secrets of wisdom!
For sound wisdom[b] is double-sided.
Know then that God exacts of you less than your iniquity deserves.[c]
7 “The searching out of God—can you attain it?
The utmost bound of Shaddai—can you arrive at it?
8 Heights of the heavens—what can you do?
Deeper than Sheol—what can you know?
9 Longer than the earth is its measure,
and broader than the sea.
10 If he passes through and shuts up,
or calls an assembly, who can turn him back?
11 For he knows worthless men;
he sees iniquity, and will he not take note of it?
12 But an empty-headed man will gain understanding
when a wild donkey’s colt is born a man.[d]
13 “If you yourself set your heart aright
and spread out your palms toward him—
14 if iniquity is in your hand, put it far away,
and let not wrong dwell in your tents—
15 surely then you shall lift up your face without blemish;
you shall be firmly set, and shall not fear.
16 For you shall forget trouble;
like waters that have flowed past you shall remember it.
17 And brighter than noonday your life shall rise;
its darkness shall be like the morning.
18 And you shall trust, because there is hope;
you shall search about you[e] and lie down in safety.

19 You shall lie down, and none shall make you afraid;
and many shall court your favor.
20 But the eyes of the wicked shall fail;
refuge has perished from them,
and their hope is the breathing out of the soul."

Notes

- a (11:2) That is, a man full of talk.
- b (11:6) Hebrew tushiyyah; see the note at 5:12.
- c (11:6) Or "God causes some of your iniquity to be forgotten."
- d (11:12) Or "when a wild donkey is born tame"; the proverb is uncertain.
- e (11:18) Or "you shall dig" (that is, set up your tent); the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 12

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "Doubtless you are the people,
and with you wisdom will die!
3 But I too have a mind, as well as you;
I fall not beneath you;
and who knows not such things as these?
4 A laughingstock to his friend I am become,
one who called upon God and he answered him;
a laughingstock is the righteous, the blameless man.
5 For misfortune there is contempt, in the thought of one at ease;
it is ready for those whose feet slip.[a]
6 At peace stand the tents of plunderers,
and secure are they who rouse God to anger,
he that carries a god in his own fist.[b]
7 "But ask the animals, and they will instruct you,
or the birds of the sky, and they will inform you;
8 or speak to the earth,[c] and it will teach you,
or let the fish of the sea explain it to you.
9 Which of all these knows not
that it is Yahweh's[d] hand that has wrought this?
10 In his hand is the soul of every living thing,
and the breath of all flesh of man.

11 Is it not the ear that tries out words,
even as the mouth tastes its meat?
12 With the aged is wisdom,
and length of days is understanding.
13 “With him are wisdom and might;
his are counsel and understanding.
14 See, he tears down, and it shall not be built;
he shuts in a man, and there shall be no opening.
15 See, he holds back the waters, and they dry up;
he sends them out, and they overturn the land.
16 With him are strength and sound wisdom;[e]
the one led astray and the one who leads astray are his.
17 He leads counselors away stripped,
and of judges he makes fools.
18 The bond of kings he loosens,
and binds a waistcloth on their loins.
19 He leads priests away stripped,
and overthrows the long-established.
20 He takes away the speech of the trusted,
and the discernment of the elders he removes.
21 He pours contempt upon nobles,
and the girdle of the mighty he slackens.
22 He uncovers deep things out of darkness
and brings deep shadow out to the light.
23 He makes nations great, and destroys them;
he spreads nations abroad, and leads them away.
24 He takes away the heart of the chiefs of the people of the land,
and makes them wander in a trackless waste.
25 They grope in the dark without light,
and he makes them stagger like a drunken man.

Notes

- a (12:5) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- b (12:6) Or “whom God has brought into his hand”; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (12:8) Or “the plants of the earth.”

- d (12:9) This is the only place in the poetic dialogue (3:1–42:6) where the name Yahweh appears outside the headings of the divine speeches; some Hebrew manuscripts read "God" (Eloah). Compare Isaiah 41:20.
- e (12:16) Hebrew tushiyyah; see the note at 5:12.

Chapter 13

1 "See, all this my eye has seen;
my ear has heard and understood it.
2 What you know, I also know;
I fall not beneath you.
3 But I would speak to Shaddai,
and to argue my case with God I desire.
4 But you are plasterers of lies;
physicians of no worth are you all.
5 O that you would keep utterly silent,
and it would be accounted wisdom to you!
6 Hear now my argument,
and to the pleas of my lips give heed.
7 Will you speak wrong on God's behalf,
and for him speak deceit?
8 Will you show him partiality?
Will you plead the case for God?
9 Will it be good when he searches you out?
Or as one mocks a man, will you mock him?
10 Reprove you he surely shall,
if you favor faces in secret.
11 Will not his loftiness strike terror into you,
and the fear of him fall heavy on you?
12 Your memorable sayings are proverbs of ashes;
your defenses are defenses of clay.
13 "Be silent before me, and I will speak;
then let come upon me what may.
14 Why should I take my flesh in my teeth
and put my life in my palm?[a]

15 See, he will slay me; I have no hope;[b]
yet my ways I will argue to his face.
16 This too shall be my salvation,
that no godless man shall come before him.
17 Listen closely to my words,
and let my declaration be in your ears.
18 See now, I have set my case in order;
I know that I shall be found in the right.
19 Who is he that will contend with me?
For then I would be silent and breathe my last.
20 "Only two things do not do to me;
then from your face I will not hide myself:
21 Remove your palm far off from me,
and let no dread of you affright me.
22 Then call, and I will answer;
or let me speak, and do you reply to me.
23 How many are my iniquities and sins?
Make me know my transgression and my sin.
24 For what cause do you hide your face
and reckon me your foe?[c]
25 Will you harass a leaf blown about,
and chase after withered chaff?
26 For you write bitter things against me,
and make me inherit the iniquities of my youth.
27 You fasten my feet in shackles
and keep close watch on all my ways;
you draw a line[d] around the soles of my feet.
28 And he[e] wastes away like a rotten thing,
like a garment that the moth has eaten.

Notes

- a (13:14) That is, why should I risk my life?
- b (13:15) So the written Hebrew text (lo', "not"). The scribal reading (lo, "in him") gives the familiar sense, "Though he slay me, yet I will hope in him." The line is a well-known crux.
- c (13:24) Hebrew 'oyev, a play on Job's name, 'Iyyov.

- d (13:27) Or “you draw a line”; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (13:28) That is, man; this verse may belong after 14:2.

Chapter 14

1 “Man, born of woman,
  is short of days and sated with trouble.
2 Like a flower he comes forth and withers;
  he flees like the shadow and does not stay.
3 And upon such a one do you open your eyes,
  and bring me[a] into judgment with you?
4 Who can bring a clean thing out of an unclean?
  Not one!
5 Since his days are fixed,
  and the count of his months rests with you,
  and you have set limits he cannot go beyond,
6 look away from him, that he may cease,
  until he finds pleasure, like a hireling, in his day.
7 “For there is hope for a tree:
  if it is cut down, it will sprout again,
  and its tender shoot will not cease.
8 Though its root grow old in the earth,
  and its stump die in the dust,
9 at the scent of water it will bud
  and put forth a branch like a young plant.
10 But a man dies and is laid low;
  a man breathes his last, and where is he?
11 Waters fail from a lake,
  and a river dries up and is parched;
12 so a man lies down and rises not up;
  until the heavens be no more they shall not wake,
  nor be stirred up from their slumber.
13 “O that you would hide me in Sheol,
  conceal me until your anger turns back,
  appoint me a set time and remember me!

14 If a man dies, shall he live again?
All the days of my hard service I would wait,
until my relief[b] should come.
15 You would call, and I would answer you;
for the work of your hands you would long.
16 For then my steps you would count,
yet not lie in wait over my sin.
17 Sealed up in a bag would be my transgression,
and you would plaster over my iniquity.
18 "Yet a mountain falling wears away to nothing,
and a crag is shifted out of its place;
19 waters wear away the stones;
their torrents wash away the soil of the earth;
so you destroy the hope of man.
20 You overpower him forever, and he passes on;
you change his face and send him away.
21 His sons come to honor, and he knows it not;
they are brought low, but he perceives it not of them.
22 Only his own flesh upon him feels pain,
and his own soul within him mourns."

Notes

- a (14:3) The Septuagint (Brenton: "caused him to enter into judgment"), Syriac, and Vulgate read "him."
- b (14:14) Hebrew ḥalifah, "change," "renewal," or "relief" (as of a guard).

Chapter 15

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said:
2 "Should a wise man answer with windy knowledge,
and fill his belly with the east wind?
3 Should he argue with talk that profits not,
or with words by which he does no good?
4 But you, you are making void the fear of God,
and curtailing devotion before God.
5 For your iniquity instructs your mouth,
and you choose the tongue of the crafty.

6 Your own mouth condemns you, not mine;
your own lips speak against you.
7 "Were you the first man to be born?
Or before the hills were you brought forth?
8 Did you hearken in God's secret council?
Have you drawn off wisdom for yourself alone?
9 What do you know that we know not?
What do you understand that is not with us?
10 Gray heads and old men alike are with us,
men greater in days than your own father.
11 Are the consolations of God too small for you,
and a word dealt gently with you?
12 Why does your heart sweep you off,
and wherefore do your eyes wink,[a]
13 that you turn your spirit against God
and let words go forth from your mouth?
14 What is man, that he should be clean,
or one born of woman, that he should be righteous?
15 See, in his holy ones he puts no trust,
and the heavens are not clean in his eyes;
16 how much less one who is abominable and corrupt,
a man who drinks injustice like water!
17 "I will declare it to you; hearken to me;
what I have beheld I will relate,
18 what wise men have told,
and their fathers did not conceal,
19 to whom alone the land was given,
and no stranger passed among them:
20 All the days of the wicked man he writhes in pain,
and the number of years laid up for the ruthless.
21 A sound of terrors is in his ears;
in peace the destroyer comes upon him.
22 He has no faith that he will escape the darkness;
the sword is waiting for him.

23 He wanders abroad for bread—'Where is it?'[b]
He knows that a day of darkness is ready at his hand.
24 Straits and distress put him in dread;
they overpower him, as a king equipped for the charge.[c]
25 Because he stretched out his hand against God
and played the mighty man against Shaddai,
26 running against him with outstretched neck,[d]
with the thick bosses of his shields;
27 Though his face is covered with fat
and his waist bulges with flesh,
28 and dwelt in cities laid waste,
in houses none should inhabit,
which were destined to become heaps;
29 he shall not be rich, nor shall his wealth endure,
nor shall their possessions[e] bend to the earth.
30 He shall not depart out of darkness;
the flame shall dry up his shoot,
and by the breath of his[f] mouth he shall pass away.
31 Let him not trust in emptiness, deceiving himself,
for emptiness shall be his recompense.
32 Before his day it shall be fulfilled,
and his palm branch shall not be green.
33 Like a vine he shall drop his unripe grapes,
and like an olive cast off his flowers.
34 For barren is the band of the profane,
and fire eats the tents where bribes are taken.
35 They conceive mischief and bring forth iniquity,
and their belly prepares deceit."

Notes

- a (15:12) Hebrew razam, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "wink" or "flash."
- b (15:23) Or, by a slight change following the Septuagint, "He is appointed as food for the vulture"; Brenton: "he has been appointed to be food for vultures."
- c (15:24) Hebrew kidor, found only here; the meaning "onset" or "attack" is uncertain.

- d (15:26) Or "with stiff neck."
- e (15:29) Hebrew minlam, found only here; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (15:30) That is, God's.

Chapter 16

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "Many such things have I heard;
troublesome comforters are you all.
3 Is there an end to windy words?
Or what provokes you, that you answer?
4 I too could speak as you do,
if your soul were in my soul's place;
I could join words together against you
and shake my head at you.
5 I could strengthen you with my mouth,
and the solace of my lips would hold back your pain.
6 "If I speak, my pain is not held back;
and if I forbear, what departs from me?
7 But now he has wearied me;
you have made desolate all my company.
8 And you have shriveled me up;[a] it is become a witness;
and my leanness rises up against me; it testifies to my face.
9 His anger has torn me and borne a grudge against me;
he has gnashed upon me with his teeth;
my adversary sharpens his eyes against me.
10 They have gaped upon me with their mouth;
with reproach they have struck my cheeks;
together they mass themselves against me.
11 God delivers me up to the unjust
and casts me into the hands of the wicked.
12 I was at ease, and he shattered me;
he seized me by the neck and dashed me to pieces;
he set me up as his target;

13 his archers[b] encircle me.
He cuts open my kidneys without mercy
and pours out my bile on the earth.
14 He breaches me, breach after breach;
like a warrior he rushes at me.
15 Sackcloth have I sewn upon my skin,
and have thrust my horn[c] into the dust.
16 My face is red with weeping,
and on my eyelids is deep shadow,
17 although there is no violence in my hands,
and my prayer is pure.
18 "Earth, do not cover my blood,
and let my cry find no place to rest.
19 Even now, see, my witness is in the heavens,
and he who vouches for me is on high.[d]
20 My interpreters[e] are my friends;
to God my eye drips tears,
21 that someone would plead for a man before God
as a person pleads for a friend.
22 For a few years more shall come,
and on a path of no return I shall go.

Notes

- a (16:8) Hebrew qamat, a rare word; perhaps "seized" or "shriveled."
- b (16:13) Or "his arrows"; Hebrew rabbav, a rare word.
- c (16:15) That is, my strength or dignity.
- d (16:19) Hebrew sahed, an Aramaic word for "witness" found only here in the Hebrew Bible. Who this witness is—God himself, or a heavenly advocate—is debated; compare 9:33 and 19:25.
- e (16:20) Or "My scorners"; Hebrew melitsay can mean either.

Chapter 17

1 "My breath is spent; my days are snuffed out;
for me the burial places wait.
2 Surely mockers are with me,
and on their provocation my eye must dwell.

3 Lay down, I pray, a pledge for me with yourself;
who else is there that will strike hands with me?[a]
4 For you have hidden their heart from understanding;
therefore you will not exalt them.
5 He who denounces friends for a share of spoil—
the eyes of his children shall fail.
6 But he has made me a byword of the peoples,
and one in whose face men spit.
7 Dim has my eye grown for grief,
and my limbs are all as a shade.
8 Upright men are aghast at this,
and the guiltless rouses himself against the profane.
9 But the just man keeps hold of his path,
and the clean of hands adds strength to strength.
10 But as for you all, come back now, I pray;
I shall not find a wise man among you.
11 "Gone by are my days; snapped are my purposes,
the cherished wishes[b] of my heart.
12 Night they turn into day;
'Light is close at hand,' they say, before the face of darkness.
13 If I hope for Sheol as my house,
if in the darkness I spread out my couch,
14 if I say to the pit,[c] 'You are my father,'
to the worm, 'My mother and my sister,'
15 where then is my hope?
And my hope—who shall see it?
16 Shall it go down to the gates of Sheol?
Shall we sink down together into the dust?"

Notes

- a (17:3) That is, who will stand surety for me?
- b (17:11) Hebrew morashe, "possessions"; here perhaps "cherished desires."
- c (17:14) Or "to corruption"; Hebrew shaḥat. With this verse begin the surviving fragments of the Aramaic Targum of Job from Qumran Cave 11 (11QtgJob), which is reported to preserve portions of 17:14–42:11 and to end at 42:11.

Chapter 18

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered and said:
2 “How long will you set snares[a] for words?
Consider, and afterward we will speak.
3 Why are we reckoned as cattle,
counted unclean[b] in your eyes?
4 You who tear yourself in your anger,
for your sake shall the earth be forsaken,
or the rock be moved out of its place?
5 “Indeed, the lamp of the wicked shall be quenched,
and no spark of his fire shall glow.
6 The light grows dark in his tent,
and his lamp above him is put out.
7 His mighty strides are cramped,
and his own counsel casts him down.
8 For he is thrust into a net by his own feet,
and upon a mesh he walks.
9 A gin grips him by the heel;
a trap holds him fast.
10 A noose for him is hidden in the ground,
and a trap for him upon the path.
11 Terrors on every side affright him
and chase him at his heels.
12 His strength is famished,
and calamity is ready at his side.
13 It eats away the members of his skin;
death’s firstborn[c] eats up his limbs.
14 He is plucked out of his tent, his safe place,
and they make him march to the king of terrors.
15 What is none of his dwells in his tent;[d]
burning sulfur is scattered across his home.
16 Beneath, his roots dry up,
and above, his branch withers.

17 The memory of him is lost from the land,
and no name is his in the open places.
18 They thrust him from light into darkness
and chase him out of the world.
19 He has neither offspring nor descendant among his people,
nor any survivor where he sojourned.
20 At his day those of the west are appalled,
and those of the east are seized with horror.[e]
21 Surely such are the dwellings of the unrighteous,
and this is the place of him who knows not God."

Notes

- a (18:2) Hebrew qintse, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "ends" or "snares."
- b (18:3) Or "stupid"; Hebrew nitminu, of uncertain meaning.
- c (18:13) Probably a deadly disease, personified as death's eldest son.
- d (18:15) Or "Nothing of his dwells in his tent"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (18:20) Or "Those who come after are appalled at his day, and those who went before are seized with horror."

Chapter 19

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "How long will you torment my soul
and crush me with words?
3 Ten times over now you have insulted me;
without shame you deal hardly with me.[a]
4 And even if in truth I have erred,
my error lodges with me.
5 If indeed you will magnify yourselves against me
and argue my disgrace against me,
6 then know that it is God who has dealt crookedly with me
and has thrown his net round about me.
7 "I cry out, 'Violence!' but get no reply;
I call for help, but there is no justice.
8 My way he has walled up, and I cannot pass,
and upon my paths he sets darkness.

9 My glory he has stripped from me
and taken the crown from my head.
10 He breaks me down on every side, and I am gone,
and my hope he has pulled up like a tree.
11 He has kindled his anger against me
and counts me as one of his adversaries.
12 His troops come on together;
they have built up their way against me
and encamp round about my tent.
13 "My brothers he has put far from me,
and those who know me are wholly estranged from me.
14 My kinsmen have failed,
and my intimate friends have forgotten me.
15 The guests in my house and my maidservants count me a stranger;
a foreigner I have become in their eyes.
16 I call to my servant, and he gives no answer;
with my own mouth I must entreat him.
17 My breath is strange to my wife,
and I am loathsome to the sons of my own womb.[b]
18 Even young children despise me;
when I rise, they speak against me.
19 All the men of my counsel abhor me,
and those whom I loved have turned against me.
20 To my skin and to my flesh my bone cleaves,
and I have escaped by the skin of my teeth.[c]
21 Have pity on me, have pity on me, O you my friends,
for the hand of God has touched me!
22 Why do you pursue me as God does,
and are not satisfied with my flesh?[d]
23 "O that my words were now written!
O that they were inscribed in a book,
24 with a pen of iron and lead
forever cut into the rock!

25 But I—I know that my redeemer[e] lives,
and at the last[f] he will stand up upon the dust.[g]
26 And after my skin has been thus stripped off,
yet from my flesh[h] I shall see God,
27 whom I myself shall see for myself,
and my own eyes shall behold, and not a stranger.[i]
My kidneys[j] are spent within my bosom.
28 If you should say, 'How shall we hound him?'
and, 'The root of the trouble lies in him,'[k]
29 be afraid of the sword for yourselves;
for wrath brings the punishments of the sword,
that you may know there is a judgment."[l]

Notes

- a (19:3) Hebrew tahkeru, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "wrong" or "stun."
- b (19:17) That is, my own brothers, born of the same womb as I. The Septuagint reads "I entreated the sons of my concubines" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (19:20) The meaning of this proverbial phrase is uncertain; it may mean "with nothing at all left."
- d (19:22) That is, by slandering me (compare the Aramaic idiom "eat pieces of" for accusing).
- e (19:25) Hebrew goʾel, the next of kin who buys back a relative's property, frees him from slavery, or avenges his blood (Leviticus 25:25; Numbers 35:19; Ruth 4:1–6); hence "vindicator" or "champion." Whether Job means God himself or another heavenly figure (compare 9:33; 16:19) is debated. Verses 25–27 are among the most difficult in the book; nearly every line is uncertain.
- f (19:25) Or "as the last"; Hebrew ʾaḥaron.
- g (19:25) Or "upon the earth," or "over my dust" (that is, my grave). The Septuagint reads verses 25–26a: "For I know that he is eternal who is about to deliver me, and to raise up upon the earth my skin that endures these sufferings" (Brenton, modernized).
- h (19:26) Or "apart from my flesh" (that is, after death) or "in my flesh"; the Hebrew preposition min can mean either "from (within)" or "without."
- i (19:27) Or "and not as a stranger."
- j (19:27) The kidneys were thought of as the seat of the emotions; that is, my heart faints with longing.
- k (19:28) So many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Vulgate; most Hebrew manuscripts read "in me."

- l (19:29) Hebrew shaddun, of uncertain meaning; some read "that there is a Judge" or "that there is Shaddai."

Chapter 20

1 Then Zophar the Naamathite answered and said:
2 "Therefore my disquieting thoughts make me answer,
because of the haste that is within me.
3 Reproof that insults me I hear,
and out of my understanding a spirit answers me.
4 Is this not known to you from ancient days,
from the time man was set on the earth,
5 that the triumphing of the wicked is short,
and the joy of the godless but for a moment?
6 Though his height mount up to the heavens,
and his head reach to the clouds,
7 like his own dung he shall perish forever;
those who saw him shall say, 'Where is he?'
8 Like a dream he flies away, and they find him not;
he is chased away like a vision of the night.
9 The eye that glimpsed him does so no more,
nor does his place behold him any longer.
10 His sons shall seek the favor of the poor,[a]
and his own hands shall give back his wealth.
11 His bones were full of his youthful vigor,
but with him it shall lie down in the dust.
12 "Though evil be sweet in his mouth,
though he hide it under his tongue,
13 though he spare it and will not let it go,
but hold it back within his palate,
14 his food is turned in his bowels;
it is the venom of cobras within him.
15 Wealth he has gulped down, and he shall spew it up;
out of his belly God shall drive it.
16 He sucks the poison of cobras;
the tongue of the viper[b] slays him.

17 He shall not gaze upon the brooks,
the torrents running with honey and curds.
18 He gives back the gain of his toil and does not swallow it;
from the profit of his trading he gets no enjoyment.
19 For the poor he has oppressed and abandoned;
a house he seized, though he did not build it.
20 "Because he knew no quiet in his belly,
he shall not escape with what he desires.
21 There was nothing left that he did not devour;
therefore his prosperity shall not endure.
22 In the fullness of his plenty he shall be in straits;
every hand of the wretched shall come upon him.
23 To fill his belly to the full,
God[c] shall send the burning of his anger upon him
and rain it upon him as his food.[d]
24 He shall flee from the iron weapon;
a bow of bronze shall pierce him through.
25 He draws it, and it comes out from his back;
the flashing blade, out from his liver;
upon him are terrors.
26 All darkness is laid up for his treasures;
a fire not blown upon shall devour him;
it shall consume what is left in his tent.
27 The heavens shall reveal his iniquity,
and the earth shall rise up against him.
28 The increase of his house shall depart,
flowing away in the day of his[e] anger.
29 This is the portion of a wicked man from God,
and the heritage appointed to him by God."

Notes

- a (20:10) Or "The poor shall oppress his sons."
- b (20:16) Hebrew ʾefʿeh, a poisonous snake; the exact species is uncertain.
- c (20:23) Hebrew "he."
- d (20:23) Hebrew biletumo, of uncertain meaning; perhaps "into his flesh" or "as his food."

- e (20:28) That is, God's.

Chapter 21

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 "Hear, O hear my word,
and let this be your consolation.
3 Bear with me, and I will speak;
and after I have spoken, mock on.
4 As for me, is my complaint against man?
And why should I not be impatient?
5 Turn to me and be appalled,
and lay your hand upon your mouth.
6 When I call it to mind, I am thrown into dismay,
and a shuddering takes hold of my flesh.
7 "Why do the wicked live on,
grow old, yes, grow mighty in power?
8 Their offspring are established in their sight with them,
and their descendants before their eyes.
9 Their houses are at peace, without fear,
and no rod of God is upon them.
10 Their bull breeds and does not fail;
their cow calves and does not miscarry.
11 They send out their little ones like a flock,
and their children dance about.
12 They lift up their voices to timbrel and lyre
and rejoice at the sound of the pipe.
13 They spend their days in prosperity,
and in a moment they go down to Sheol.[a]
14 Yet they say to God, 'Depart from us!
We have no desire for the knowledge of your ways.
15 What is Shaddai, that we should serve him?
And what does it profit us if we entreat him?'
16 See, is not their prosperity in their own hand?
The counsel of the wicked is far from me.

17 “How often is the lamp of the wicked put out,
and does their calamity come upon them?
How often does he apportion pains in his anger?
18 How often are they as stubble in the face of the wind,
as chaff whirled off by the tempest?
19 You say, ‘God stores up his iniquity for his sons.’
Let him repay it to the man himself, that he may know it!
20 Let his own eyes see his destruction,
and let him drink of the wrath of Shaddai.
21 For what does he care for his house after him,
when the number of his months is cut off?
22 Shall anyone teach God knowledge,
seeing that he judges those on high?
23 One dies in his full strength,
wholly at ease and secure,
24 his pails[b] full of milk
and the marrow of his bones moist.
25 And another dies with a bitter soul,
having never eaten of good things.
26 Alike they lie down in the dust,
and the worm covers them.
27 “See, I know your thoughts,
and the schemes by which you would wrong me.
28 For you say, ‘Where is the house of the prince?
And where is the tent in which the wicked dwelt?’
29 Have you never inquired of the wayfarers?
Do you not acknowledge their signs,
30 that the wicked are spared on the day of disaster
and rescued on the day of wrath?[c]
31 Who declares his way to his face?
And for what he has done, who repays him?
32 When he is carried to the graves,
watch is kept over his tomb.

33 Sweet to him are the clods of the valley;
and after him all mankind draws on,
as before him there were without number.
34 How then do you comfort me with emptiness,
when of your answers there remains only faithlessness?”

Notes

- a (21:13) Or “in peace they go down to Sheol.”
- b (21:24) Hebrew ʿatinav, found only here; the meaning is uncertain: perhaps “his pails” or “his haunches.” The Septuagint reads “his inwards are full of fat” (Brenton, modernized).
- c (21:30) That is, they are rescued; or “from the day of wrath they are led away.”

Chapter 22

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite answered and said:
2 “Can a man be of use to God?
Surely the wise man is of use to himself.
3 Is it any delight to Shaddai if you are righteous,
or gain to him if you make your ways blameless?
4 Is it for your fear of him that he reproves you,
that he enters with you into judgment?
5 Is not your evil great,
and is there no end to your iniquities?
6 For you have taken pledges of your brothers for nothing
and stripped the naked of their clothing.
7 No water have you given the weary to drink,
and from the hungry you have withheld bread.
8 The man of arm[a]—his was the land,
and the favored of face dwelt in it.
9 Widows you have sent away empty,
and the arms of the fatherless were crushed.
10 Therefore snares are round about you,
and sudden dread affrights you,
11 or a darkness, that you see nothing,
and a mass of waters overwhelms you.

12 “Is not God in the height of the heavens?
And see the summit[b] of the stars, how high they are!
13 And you say, ‘What does God know?
Can he judge through the thick cloud?
14 Clouds are a covering to him, so that he sees not,
and on the vault[c] of the heavens he walks about.’
15 Will you keep to the ancient path
which men of iniquity have trodden,
16 who were snatched away before their time,
whose foundation was poured out as a river,
17 who said to God, ‘Depart from us,’
and, ‘What can Shaddai do to them?’[d]
18 Yet he filled their houses with good—
but the counsel of the wicked is far from me.
19 The righteous see and are glad,
and the innocent laughs them to scorn:
20 ‘Truly cut off are those who rose against us,[e]
and their leavings the flame has eaten.’
21 “Come to terms with him, I pray, and be at peace;
thereby good shall come to you.
22 Receive, I pray, instruction from his mouth,
and lay up his words in your heart.
23 If you return to Shaddai, you shall be built up;
if you remove iniquity far from your tents,
24 and lay your gold ore in the dust,
and the gold of Ophir[f] among the stones of the wadis,
25 then Shaddai shall be your gold ore
and silver in heaps[g] for you.
26 For then in Shaddai you shall delight
and lift up your face to God.
27 You shall entreat him, and he shall hear you,
and your vows you shall pay.
28 You shall decree a thing, and it shall be established for you,
and upon your ways light shall shine.

29 When they are brought low, you shall say, ‘Lift up!’[h]
and the one of downcast eyes he will save.
30 He will deliver even one who is not innocent;
he shall be delivered through the cleanness of your hands.

Notes

- a (22:8) That is, the man of power.
- b (22:12) Hebrew “head.”
- c (22:14) Hebrew ḥug, the circle or dome of the heavens.
- d (22:17) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint (“What will the Lord do to us?” Brenton) and Syriac read “to us.”
- e (22:20) Hebrew qimanu, found only here; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (22:24) Ophir was a land famed for fine gold, perhaps in southern Arabia or East Africa; its location is unknown. The Septuagint reads “Sophir” (Brenton).
- g (22:25) Hebrew toʿafot, a rare word; perhaps “heaps” or “choice silver.”
- h (22:29) Or “it is pride”; the Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.

Chapter 23

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 “Still today my complaint is defiance;[a]
his[b] hand lies heavy over my sighing.
3 O that I knew where I might find him,
that I might come even to his dwelling place!
4 I would set my cause in order before him
and fill my mouth with arguments.
5 I would know the words with which he would answer me,
and understand what he would say to me.
6 Would he contend with me in the greatness of his power?
No; he would surely give heed to me.
7 There a just man might argue it out with him,
and I should go free from my judge for all time.
8 “See, I go forward, and he is not there,
and backward, and I do not perceive him;
9 on the left hand, when he works, I behold him not;
he turns aside to the right hand, and I see him not.[c]
10 But he knows the way that is with me;
when he has tried me, I shall come forth as gold.

11 My foot has held fast to his steps;
his way I have kept and not turned aside.
12 From the commandment of his lips I have not departed;
more than my own portion[d] I have treasured the words of his mouth.
13 But he is one,[e] and who can turn him?
What his soul desires, that he does.
14 For he will complete what is appointed for me,
and many such things are with him.
15 Therefore I am dismayed at his presence;
when I consider, I am in dread of him.
16 For God has made my heart faint,
and Shaddai has dismayed me;
17 Yet I am not silenced by the darkness,
by the gloom that covers my face.[f]

Notes

- a (23:2) Hebrew meri, "rebellion"; the Syriac, Targum, and Vulgate read mar, "bitter."
- b (23:2) So the Septuagint ("his hand has been made heavy upon my groaning," Brenton) and Syriac; the Hebrew reads "my hand."
- c (23:9) "Forward," "backward," "left," and "right" may also be read as "east," "west," "north," and "south."
- d (23:12) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint (Brenton) and Vulgate read "in my bosom."
- e (23:13) Or "he is unchangeable"; perhaps, by a slight change, "he has chosen."
- f (23:17) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain; or "Yet I am not silenced by the darkness, by the thick darkness that covers my face."

Chapter 24

1 "Why are times of judgment not stored up by Shaddai?
Why do those who know him never witness his days?[a]
2 Some remove landmarks;
they seize flocks and pasture them.
3 The donkey of the fatherless they drive away;
they take the widow's ox for a pledge.
4 They push the needy out of the way;
the lowly of the earth are made to hide, all of them alike.

5 See, like wild donkeys in the wilderness
they go forth to their toil, seeking eagerly for food;
the desert yields bread for their children.
6 In the field they reap his fodder,[b]
and they glean the vineyard of the wicked.
7 Naked they pass the night, without clothing,
and they have no covering in the cold.
8 With the downpour of the mountains they are drenched,
and for lack of shelter they hug the rock.
9 They snatch the fatherless from the breast,
and against the poor they take a pledge.
10 Naked they go about, without clothing,
and hungry, they carry the sheaves.
11 Within their walls[c] they crush out the olives;
the vats they tread, and go thirsty.
12 Out of the city the dying make their moan,
and the wounded soul shouts for aid;
yet God lays no charge of folly.[d]
13 "These are among those who rebel against the light;
they do not know its ways
nor stay in its paths.
14 At the light the murderer rises;
he kills the poor and needy,
and in the night he is like the thief.
15 The eye of the adulterer also watches for the twilight,
saying, 'No eye shall see me,'
and he puts a covering on his face.
16 In darkness men break through into houses;
by daytime they seal themselves in;
light they know not.
17 For to all of them deep shadow is morning,
for they are familiar with the terrors of deep shadow.

18 “Swift is he[e] upon the face of the waters;
cursed is their portion in the land;
he turns not toward the way of the vineyards.
19 As drought and heat carry off melted snow,
so Sheol carries off those who have sinned.
20 The womb forgets him; the worm feeds sweetly on him;
he is no longer remembered,
and iniquity is broken like a tree.
21 He feeds upon[f] the barren woman who does not bear,
and to the widow he does no good.
22 Yet God[g] by his might draws out the life of the strong;
up they rise, when they had no trust that they would live.
23 He grants them to be secure, and they lean on it,
but his eyes are over their ways.
24 Raised up for a little, then they are not;
they are laid low, gathered in like everyone else;
like the tops of the ears of grain they are lopped.
25 If this is not so, who can prove me wrong
and show that my words are worthless?”

Notes

- a (24:1) The arrangement of chapters 24–27 is disputed. In their present form, some speeches seem to be missing or out of place (Bildad’s third speech in chapter 25 is very short, and Zophar has no third speech), and parts of 24:18–25 and 27:13–23 sound more like the friends than like Job. Many scholars rearrange these chapters; this translation follows the traditional order.
- b (24:6) Hebrew belilo, “his fodder,” or, by a different division of the letters, “at night”; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (24:11) Hebrew shurotam, a rare word; perhaps the terrace walls of the olive groves.
- d (24:12) So the Hebrew (tiflah); the Syriac reads “gives no heed to their prayer.”
- e (24:18) Verses 18–24 are difficult, and many take them as Job quoting his friends’ view (“You say …”).
- f (24:21) Or “He wrongs”; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- g (24:22) Hebrew “he.”

Chapter 25

1 Then Bildad the Shuhite answered and said:

2 “Dominion and dread are with him;
he makes peace in his high places.
3 Can his bands be counted?
And over whom does his light not rise?
4 How then can a man be righteous with God?
Or how can one born of woman be clean?
5 See, even the moon—it does not shine,
and the stars are not clean in his eyes;
6 How much less a mortal, who is a maggot,
a human being, who is a worm!”[a]

Notes

- a (25:6) Bildad’s third speech is unusually short; some scholars think part of it is preserved in 26:5–14 (see the note at 24:1).

Chapter 26

1 Then Job answered and said:
2 “What help you have given to the powerless!
What rescue to an arm with no might!
3 How you have counseled him who has no wisdom,
and plentifully made known sound wisdom![a]
4 With whose aid have you spoken words,
and whose spirit has gone out from you?
5 “The shades[b] writhe
beneath the waters and their inhabitants.
6 Naked is Sheol before him,
and Abaddon[c] has no covering.
7 He spreads the north over the empty place;
he suspends the earth on nothingness.
8 He binds up the waters in his thick clouds,
and the cloud is not torn beneath them.
9 He shuts in the face of the full moon[d]
and spreads out over it his cloud.
10 A circle he has traced on the surface of the waters,
where light and darkness meet.

11 The pillars of the heavens tremble
and are astounded at his rebuke.
12 By his power he stilled[e] the sea,
and by his understanding he struck down Rahab.[f]
13 By his breath the heavens are made fair;[g]
his hand has pierced the fleeing serpent.[h]
14 See, these are the outskirts of his ways;
and how faint a whisper of a word we hear of him!
But the thunder of his mighty deeds—who can understand?"

Notes

- a (26:3) Hebrew tushiyyah; see the note at 5:12.
- b (26:5) Hebrew repha'im, the shades of the dead. The Septuagint reads "Shall giants be born from under the water?" (Brenton).
- c (26:6) Abaddon, "destruction," is a poetic name for the realm of the dead (compare 28:22; 31:12; Revelation 9:11).
- d (26:9) Or "his throne"; the Hebrew kisseh (throne) and keseh (full moon) are spelled alike.
- e (26:12) Or "stirred up."
- f (26:12) Rahab is a mythic sea monster representing chaos; see the note at 9:13. The Septuagint reads "by his wisdom the whale has been overthrown" (Brenton).
- g (26:13) Hebrew shifrah, found only here; perhaps "fair" or "clear."
- h (26:13) Or "the gliding serpent," as in Isaiah 27:1, where it describes Leviathan. The Septuagint reads "by a command he has slain the apostate dragon" (Brenton).

Chapter 27

1 And Job again took up his discourse[a] and said:
2 "As God lives, who has taken away my right,
and Shaddai, who has made my soul bitter,
3 as long as my breath is in me,
and the spirit of God is in my nostrils,
4 my lips shall not speak injustice,
nor shall my tongue utter deceit.
5 Far be it from me that I should declare you in the right;
till I breathe my last I will not put away my integrity from me.
6 To my righteousness I cling and will not loosen my grip;
my heart shall not taunt me for one of my days.

7 “May my enemy be treated like the wicked,
my opponent like the unjust.
8 For what is the hope of the godless when he is cut off,
when God takes away his soul?
9 Will God hear his cry
when distress comes upon him?
10 Will he take delight in Shaddai?
Will he call upon God at all times?
11 I will teach you concerning the hand of God;
what is with Shaddai I will not conceal.
12 See, all of you have seen it yourselves;
why then have you become altogether vain?
13 “This is the portion of a wicked man with God,[b]
and the heritage of oppressors, which they receive from Shaddai:
14 If his sons are multiplied, it is for the sword,
and his offspring shall not be satisfied with bread.
15 Those who survive him shall be buried by the plague,[c]
and his widows shall not weep.
16 Though he heap up silver like dust
and prepare clothing like clay,
17 he may prepare it, but the righteous shall wear it,
and the innocent shall divide the silver.
18 He builds his house like the moth,[d]
like a booth that a watchman makes.
19 Rich he lies down, but he shall not be gathered;[e]
he opens his eyes, and he is not.
20 Terrors overtake him like waters;
by night a whirlwind steals him away.
21 The east wind lifts him, and away he goes;
it whirls him from his place.
22 It hurls itself upon him[f] and does not spare;
he flees headlong from its hand.
23 It claps its palms against him
and whistles him out of his place.

Notes

- a (27:1) Hebrew mashal, a proverb, parable, or poem; so also 29:1.
- b (27:13) Many scholars think 27:13–23 belongs to the missing third speech of Zophar (see the note at 24:1), since it repeats the friends' teaching about the fate of the wicked (compare 20:29).
- c (27:15) Hebrew "by death," probably pestilence (compare Jeremiah 15:2).
- d (27:18) Hebrew ʿash, "moth"; some read ʿakkavish, "spider" (compare 8:14). The Septuagint has both: "like moths, and like a spider's web" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (27:19) Or, following the Septuagint ("shall not continue," Brenton) and Syriac, "but he shall do so no more."
- f (27:22) Or "He (God) hurls at him."

Chapter 28

1 "Surely there is a source[a] for silver,
and a place for gold, which men refine.
2 Iron is taken out of the dust,
and stone is poured out as copper.
3 Man sets a limit to darkness,
and out to every far edge he explores
for ore in gloom and deep shadow.
4 He breaks open a shaft away from where men sojourn;[b]
forgotten by the foot,
they hang far from men; they swing to and fro.
5 The earth—out of it comes bread,
but beneath it is turned up as by fire.
6 Its stones are the place of sapphire,[c]
and it has dust of gold.
7 A path no bird of prey knows,
nor has the falcon's[d] eye seen it.
8 Proud animals[e] have never walked on it,
and no lion has prowled there.
9 Against the flint man puts forth his hand;
he overturns mountains by the roots.
10 In the rocks he cuts out channels,
and his eye sees every precious thing.
11 He dams up the streams so they do not flow,
and brings hidden things out into the light.

12 “But wisdom—where shall it be found?
And where is the place of understanding?
13 Man does not know its worth,[f]
nor is it found in the land of the living.
14 The abyss says, ‘It is not within me,’
and the sea says, ‘It is not beside me.’
15 Choice gold[g] shall not be paid for it,
nor silver weighed as the cost of it.
16 It cannot be valued with the gold of Ophir,
with precious onyx[h] or sapphire.
17 Gold and glass[i] cannot equal it,
nor can vessels of fine gold be its exchange.
18 Coral and crystal[j] are not worth mentioning;
the acquiring of wisdom is above that of pearls.[k]
19 The topaz[l] of Cush[m] shall not match it;
with refined gold it shall not be weighed.
20 “Wisdom, then—from where does it come?
And where is the place of understanding?
21 It is hidden from the eyes of all living
and concealed from the birds of the heavens.
22 Abaddon and Death declare,
‘With our ears we heard a report of it.’
23 God discerns the road to it,
and it is he who knows where it dwells.
24 For he looks to the ends of the earth
and sees under all the heavens,
25 When he gave the wind its weight
and measured out the waters,
26 when he made a decree for the rain
and a way for the thunderbolt,
27 then he saw it and declared it;
he established it, and searched it out also.

28 And to man he said,
'See, the fear of the Lord[n]—that is wisdom,
and to turn aside from evil is understanding.' "

Notes

- a (28:1) Hebrew motsa', "a place of going out," that is, a mine.
- b (28:4) The Hebrew of this verse is obscure; it seems to describe miners let down by ropes into a shaft.
- c (28:6) Hebrew sappir, probably lapis lazuli rather than the modern sapphire; so also 28:16. The Septuagint reads "sapphire" (Brenton).
- d (28:7) Hebrew 'ayyah, a bird of prey, perhaps a falcon or kite; the identification is uncertain.
- e (28:8) Hebrew bene shaḥats, "sons of pride," perhaps wild beasts of the larger kinds; the phrase occurs only here and in 41:34.
- f (28:13) Hebrew "its value"; the Septuagint reads "its way" (Brenton).
- g (28:15) Hebrew segor, a rare word for gold, perhaps "closed (refined) gold."
- h (28:16) Hebrew shoham, a precious stone of uncertain identification: onyx, carnelian, or lapis lazuli have been suggested. The ancient names of precious stones in this passage cannot be identified with certainty. The Septuagint reads "gold of Sophir, with the precious onyx and sapphire" (Brenton).
- i (28:17) Hebrew zekhukhit, found only here, probably glass, then a costly material. The Septuagint reads "crystal" (Brenton).
- j (28:18) Hebrew ra'mot and gavish, both uncertain; perhaps "coral" and "crystal" (or "jasper"). The Septuagint reads "Coral and fine pearl" (Brenton).
- k (28:18) Hebrew peninim, perhaps pearls, red coral, or rubies; uncertain.
- l (28:19) Hebrew pitdah, probably topaz or chrysolite (peridot), which came from an island in the Red Sea; uncertain. The Septuagint reads "the topaz of Ethiopia" (Brenton).
- m (28:19) That is, the upper Nile region (Ethiopia and Sudan).
- n (28:28) Hebrew 'Adonai; this is its only occurrence in Job. Some Hebrew manuscripts are reported to read YHWH ("Yahweh").

Chapter 29

1 And Job again took up his discourse and said:
2 "O that I were as in the months of old,
as in the days when God watched over me,
3 when his lamp shone over my head,
and by his light I walked through darkness,
4 as I was in the days of my autumn,[a]
when the counsel[b] of God was upon my tent,

5 when Shaddai was still with me,
and my young men[c] were round about me,
6 when my steps were washed with curds,
and the rock poured out for me streams of oil!
7 When I went out to the gate of the city,
when I set up my seat in the square,
8 the young men saw me and hid themselves,
and the aged rose and stood;
9 princes refrained from speaking
and laid their hand upon their mouth;
10 the voice of the nobles was hushed,
and their tongue cleaved to their palate.
11 For the ear heard, and called me blessed,
and the eye saw, and bore witness for me,
12 because I delivered the poor who cried out,
and the fatherless who had none to help him.
13 The blessing of him who was perishing came upon me,
and the widow's heart I made to sing for joy.
14 Righteousness I put on, and it clothed me;
like a robe and a turban was my justice.
15 Eyes I was to the blind,
and feet to the lame was I.
16 A father I was to the needy,
and the cause of him I knew not I searched out.
17 And I broke the jaws of the unrighteous
and made him drop the prey from his teeth.
18 "Then I thought, 'In my nest I shall breathe my last,
and as the sand[d] I shall multiply days.
19 My root is spread out to the waters,
and the dew lodges all night on my branch.
20 My glory is fresh with me,
and my bow is renewed in my hand.'
21 "To me they listened and waited,
and kept silence for my counsel.

22 After my word they did not speak again,
and my speech dropped upon them.
23 They waited for me as for the rain,
and they opened their mouths wide as for the spring rain.
24 When they lost hope, I smiled at them,
and they never dimmed the brightness of my face.[e]
25 I chose their way and sat as chief,
and dwelt like a king among the troops,
like one who comforts mourners.

Notes

- a (29:4) That is, my prime; the season of harvest and fullness.
- b (29:4) Hebrew sod, "council" or "intimate friendship"; some read, by a slight change, "when God protected my tent."
- c (29:5) Or "my children."
- d (29:18) Or "as the phoenix"; Hebrew ḥol, "sand," was understood by some ancient Jewish interpreters as the name of the long-lived phoenix. The Septuagint reads "as the stem of a palm tree" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (29:24) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.

Chapter 30

1 "But now they laugh at me,
men younger in days than I,
whose fathers I would have disdained
to set with the dogs of my flock.
2 Indeed, what was the strength of their hands to me,
men in whom vigor[a] had perished?
3 Through want and hard famine they are gaunt;
they gnaw the dry ground,
the gloom[b] of waste and desolation.
4 They pluck saltwort[c] by the bushes,
and the roots of the broom tree[d] are their food.
5 From the community they are driven out;
men shout after them as after a thief.
6 In the gullies of the wadis they must dwell,
in holes of the earth and of the rocks.

7 Among the bushes they bray;
under the nettles[e] they huddle together.
8 Sons of a fool, yes, sons of no name,
they have been whipped out of the land.
9 "And now I am become their song;
I am a byword to them.
10 They abhor me; they keep far from me;
from my face they do not withhold spittle.
11 Because he[f] unstrung my cord and humbled me,
before me they have thrown off the bridle.
12 On my right hand the rabble[g] rises up;
they thrust away my feet
and cast up against me their ways of destruction.
13 They break up my path;
they promote my calamity;
no one helps them.[h]
14 As through a broad gap they come on;
amid the ruin they come rolling in.
15 Terrors are rolled upon me;
my nobility is chased off as by the wind,
and my welfare is gone by like a cloud.
16 "And now my soul is poured out within me;
days of affliction have taken hold of me.
17 By night my bones are pierced within me,
and my gnawing pains take no rest.
18 With great force God grabs my clothing;[i]
he grips me like the neck of my tunic.
19 He has cast me into the mire,
and I am become like dust and ashes.
20 I cry out to you, but you do not answer;
I stand up, but you merely stare at me.[j]
21 You are turned to be cruel to me;
with the might of your hand you persecute me.

22 You raise me up into the wind; you make me ride upon it;
and you melt me away in the crash of the tempest.[k]
23 For I know that you will bring me to death,
to the house appointed for all living.
24 "Yet does a man not put out his hand when falling into ruin,
or in his disaster raise a cry for this?[l]
25 Did I not weep for those in hard times?
Was I not sorrowful for the poor?
26 For I looked for good, and evil arrived;
I waited for light, and gloom arrived.
27 My inward parts boil and are not still;
days of affliction confront me.
28 I go about blackened, but not by the sun;
I stand up in the assembly and cry for help.
29 I am become a brother to jackals
and a companion to ostriches.[m]
30 My skin grows black and falls from me,
and my bones burn with heat.
31 My lyre is turned into mourning,
and my flute into the sound of weepers.

Notes

- a (30:2) Hebrew kelaḥ; see the note at 5:26.
- b (30:3) Hebrew ʾemesh, usually "yesterday"; here perhaps "gloom" or "by night." The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- c (30:4) Hebrew malluaḥ, found only here; probably the salty orache (saltbush), eaten by the very poor. The identification is uncertain.
- d (30:4) Hebrew rotem, the white broom, a desert shrub whose roots are bitter; perhaps the roots were burned for warmth rather than eaten.
- e (30:7) Hebrew ḥarul, perhaps nettles, chickling vetch, or wild mustard; uncertain.
- f (30:11) That is, God. So the scribal reading; the written Hebrew text has "I have loosed."
- g (30:12) Hebrew firḥaḥ, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "brood" or "rabble."
- h (30:13) Or "with no one to restrain them"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- i (30:18) So the Septuagint ("my disease has taken hold of my garment," Brenton, modernized); the Hebrew reads "my garment disguises itself." The verse is uncertain.

- j (30:20) So the Hebrew; one Hebrew manuscript and the Vulgate are reported to read "you do not look at me."
- k (30:22) The written and the scribal readings of the last word differ (tushiyyah, teshu'ah); the line is uncertain.
- l (30:24) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- m (30:29) Hebrew benot ya'anah, traditionally "ostriches," though some think "owls" or "eagle-owls"; jackals and ostriches both have mournful cries. The Septuagint reads "a brother of monsters, and a companion of ostriches" (Brenton).

Chapter 31

1 "A covenant I made with my eyes;
how then could I gaze upon a virgin?
2 And what would be the portion from God above,
and the heritage from Shaddai on high?
3 Is not ruin for the wicked,
and misfortune for those who work wickedness?
4 Does he not see my ways
and number all my steps?
5 "If I have walked with falsehood,
and my foot has hastened to deceit—
6 let me be weighed in a just balance,
and let God know my integrity—
7 if my steps have strayed from the road,
and my heart has followed after my eyes,
or any stain has stuck to my palms,
8 then let me sow, and another eat,
and let my offspring[a] be rooted out.
9 "If my heart has been lured toward a woman,
and at my neighbor's doorway I lay in ambush,
10 then let my wife grind for another,
and let others bow down upon her.
11 For that would be a lewd deed;
that would be an iniquity for the judges.
12 For it is a fire that eats down to Abaddon,
and it would tear out by the roots all my produce.

13 “If I have despised the cause of my manservant or my maidservant
when they contended with me,
14 what then shall I do when God rises up?
When he visits, what shall I answer him?
15 Did not he who made me in the womb make him,
and did not One fashion us in the womb?
16 “If I have withheld the poor from their desire,
or caused the eyes of the widow to fail,
17 or have eaten my morsel by myself,
and the fatherless has not eaten of it—
18 for from my youth he grew up with me as with a father,
and from my mother’s womb I guided her[b]—
19 if I have seen one dying for want of garments,
or a poor man with nothing to cover him,
20 if his loins have not blessed me,
and he was not warmed with the fleece of my sheep,
21 if I have lifted my hand against the fatherless
because I saw my help in the gate,
22 then let my shoulder blade fall from the shoulder,
and my arm be broken from its socket.[c]
23 For disaster from God terrified me,
and before his majesty I was helpless.
24 “If I have made gold my confidence,
or called fine gold my trust,
25 if I have rejoiced because my wealth was great,
and because my hand had found much,
26 if I have looked at the light[d] when it shone,
or the moon moving in splendor,
27 and my heart was secretly drawn away,
and my hand threw a kiss from my mouth,[e]
28 that too would be an iniquity for the judges,
for I would have denied God above.
29 “If I have been glad at the downfall of him who hated me,
or lifted myself up because evil had found him—

30 but I have not let my palate sin
by asking for his life with a curse—
31 if the people of my household have never said,
'Is there anyone who did not get his fill of Job's meat?'
32 the sojourner has not lodged in the street;
my doors I have opened to the traveler[f]—
33 if I have covered my transgressions like Adam,[g]
by hiding my iniquity in my bosom,
34 because I feared the crowd,
or the scorn of clans frightened me,
and so I kept quiet and stayed inside—
35 O that I had one to hear me!
Here is my mark;[h] let Shaddai answer me!
And the scroll that my adversary has written—
36 surely on my shoulder I would bear it;
I would bind it on myself as crowns.
37 The number of my steps I would declare to him;
like a prince I would draw near to him.
38 "If my land cries out against me,
and its furrows weep together,
39 if I have eaten its yield without payment,
or caused the soul of its owners to breathe out,
40 let thorns come up instead of wheat,
and stinking weeds[i] instead of barley."
The words of Job are ended.

Notes

- a (31:8) Or "my crops."
- b (31:18) That is, the widow. The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- c (31:22) Hebrew qanah, "reed," here the upper arm bone.
- d (31:26) That is, the sun.
- e (31:27) An ancient gesture of worship toward the sun or moon.
- f (31:32) So the ancient versions; the Hebrew reads "to the road."
- g (31:33) Or "as men do"; Hebrew 'adam.
- h (31:35) Hebrew taw, the last letter of the Hebrew alphabet, written as a cross-shaped mark; here, Job's signature on his sworn statement.

- i (31:40) Hebrew bo'shah, found only here; some noxious weed, perhaps cockle. The identification is uncertain.

Chapter 32

1 So these three men ceased to answer Job, because he was righteous
in his own eyes. 2 Then the anger of Elihu[a] the son of Barachel[b] the
Buzite,[c] of the family of Ram, was kindled. Against Job his anger
was kindled, because he declared himself righteous rather than God.
3 And against his three friends his anger was kindled, because they
had found no answer, and yet had condemned Job.[d] 4 Now Elihu had
waited to speak to Job, because they were older in days than he. 5 And
when Elihu saw that there was no answer in the mouth of the three
men, his anger was kindled.

6 And Elihu the son of Barachel the Buzite answered and said:

"Young am I in days,
and you are very old;
therefore I held back and was afraid
to declare my knowledge to you.
7 I said, 'Let days speak,
and let the multitude of years make wisdom known.'
8 But truly it is a spirit in man,
and the breath of Shaddai, that makes them understand.
9 It is not the many in years[e] who are wise,
nor the aged who understand what is right.
10 Therefore I say, 'Listen to me;
let me declare my knowledge, I also.'
11 "Look, I waited while you spoke;
I listened to your arguments
while you hunted for words.
12 Yes, I gave you my close attention,
and see, there was none who refuted Job,
none among you who answered his words.
13 Beware lest you say, 'We have found wisdom;
God may vanquish him, not man.'

14 He has not directed his words against me,
and with your speeches I will not answer him.
15 “They are dismayed; they answer no more;
words have departed from them.
16 And must I tarry, since silent they are,
since idle they stand, replying no further?
17 I too will answer my share;
I too will declare my knowledge.
18 For I am full of words;
the spirit within my belly constrains me.
19 Inside, I am like wine with no outlet,
like new wineskins about to burst.
20 Let me speak, that I may find relief;
let me open my lips and answer.
21 Let me not, I pray, show partiality to any man,
nor use flattering titles toward any man.
22 For I do not know how to give flattering titles;
else my Maker would soon take me away.

Notes

- a (32:2) Elihu means “He is my God.” He is the only speaker in the book whose name is a clearly Israelite one.
- b (32:2) Barachel means “God blesses.”
- c (32:2) Buz was a son of Nahor, Abraham’s brother (Genesis 22:21); compare Jeremiah 25:23. The Septuagint adds “of the country of Ausis” (Uz) (Brenton).
- d (32:3) So the standard Hebrew text. According to an ancient Jewish tradition this is one of the “corrections of the scribes,” and the original read “and so had condemned God,” that is, by failing to answer they had in effect put God in the wrong.
- e (32:9) So the Septuagint, Syriac, and Vulgate; the Hebrew reads “the great.”

Chapter 33

1 “But now hear, O Job, my speech,
and to all my words give ear.
2 See now, I have opened my mouth;
my tongue in my palate speaks.

3 Upright of heart are the sayings I utter;
plain knowledge my lips shall pour forth.
4 The Spirit of God has made me,
and the breath of Shaddai gives me life.
5 If you are able, answer me;
set your words in order before me; take your stand.
6 See, I am toward God as you are;
from clay I too was nipped off.[a]
7 See, dread of me need not terrify you,
nor my pressure[b] be heavy upon you.
8 "Surely you have spoken in my ears,
and the sound of your words I heard:
9 'Clean am I, without transgression;
pure[c] am I, and there is no iniquity in me.
10 See, he finds occasions[d] against me;
he counts me as his enemy.
11 In the stocks he sets fast my feet;
over every path of mine he keeps watch.'
12 Lo, herein you are not just—so I reply—
for mightier than mortal is God.
13 Why do you contend against him,
saying that he answers none of man's[e] words?
14 Once God utters it, yes, twice,
yet it is unheeded by man:
15 in a dream, a vision of the night,
when deep sleep falls upon men,
in slumberings upon the bed;
16 then he uncovers the ears of men
and seals their instruction,[f]
17 to turn man aside from his deed
and to conceal pride from a man;
18 he keeps back his soul from the pit,
and his life from passing over by the javelin.[g]

19 “He is also chastened with pain upon his bed,
and with continual strife in his bones,
20 till his very life abhors food,
and his appetite the choicest dish.
21 His flesh is consumed away from sight,
and his bones, once unseen, are laid bare.
22 And his soul draws near to the pit,
and his life to those who bring death.[h]
23 Should there stand by him a messenger,
an interpreter,[i] one out of a thousand,
to make plain to a man his uprightness,
24 and he is gracious to him and says,
‘Deliver him from going down to the pit;
I have found a ransom,’
25 let his flesh become fresher[j] than a child’s;
let him return to the days of his youthful vigor.
26 To God he entreats, and finds favor with him;
with gladness he gazes upon his face,
and to the mortal he gives back his just standing.
27 Before men he chants and declares,
‘Sin I did, and twisted the straight,
yet no like return was dealt me.[k]
28 He has ransomed my soul from going down to the pit,
and my life will see the light.’
29 “See, all these things God works,
twice, three times, with a man,
30 to bring his soul back from the pit,
so that the light of life may shine on him.
31 Attend, O Job; hearken to me;
hold your peace while I talk.
32 If you have words, answer me;
speak, for I desire to justify you.
33 If not, then hearken to me;
keep still, and wisdom I shall impart.”

Notes

- a (33:6) That is, pinched off, as a potter takes a piece of clay.
- b (33:7) Hebrew ʾekef, found only here; perhaps "pressure" or "burden."
- c (33:9) Hebrew ḥaf, found only here; "clean" or "innocent."
- d (33:10) Or "pretexts"; Hebrew tenuʾot, a rare word.
- e (33:13) Hebrew "his"; perhaps "answers for none of his own deeds."
- f (33:16) Or "frightens them with warnings"; the Septuagint reads "he scares them with such fearful visions" (Brenton); the Hebrew is uncertain.
- g (33:18) Or "crossing the river (of death)"; Hebrew shelaḥ can mean a weapon or a channel.
- h (33:22) Or "to the angels of death," or "to the place of the dead."
- i (33:23) Hebrew melits, an interpreter or spokesman; compare 16:20. The Septuagint reads "Though there should be a thousand messengers of death, not one of them shall wound him" (Brenton).
- j (33:25) Hebrew rutafash, found only here; the meaning "grow fresh" is a guess from context.
- k (33:27) Or "it was not worth it for me."

Chapter 34

1 Then Elihu answered and said:
2 "Hear my words, you wise men,
and you who know, give ear to me;
3 for the ear tests words
as the palate tastes food.
4 Let us choose for ourselves what is right;
let us know among ourselves what is good.
5 For Job has said, 'I am righteous,
and God has taken away my right;
6 though in the right, I am reckoned false;
past healing is my wound,[a] though there is no offense in me.'
7 What man is like Job,
who drinks up scoffing like water,
8 and goes in company with the workers of iniquity
and walks with men of wickedness?
9 For he has said, 'A person gains nothing
by delighting in God.'

10 “Therefore, you men of heart,[b] hear me:
far be it from God that he should do wickedness,
and from Shaddai that he should do wrong.
11 For he repays people for what they do
and brings upon each the results of his own conduct.
12 Surely, of a truth, God will not do wickedly,
and Shaddai will not pervert justice.
13 Who entrusted the earth into his keeping?
Who set in place[c] the entire world?
14 If he should set his heart upon himself,[d]
and gather to himself his spirit and his breath,
15 all living creatures would die together,
and humanity would go back to dust.
16 “If you have understanding, hear this;
listen to the sound of my words.
17 Shall even one who hates justice govern?
And will you condemn the Righteous Mighty One,
18 who says to a king, ‘Worthless one!’
to nobles, ‘Wicked man!’
19 who lifts not the face of rulers,
nor sets the wealthy ahead of the lowly,
since every one is wrought by his hands?
20 They die in an instant, in the middle of the night;
people are shaken and pass away,
and the powerful are removed without a human hand.
21 For his eyes are upon the ways of a man,
and he sees all his steps.
22 There is no darkness nor deep shadow
where the workers of iniquity may hide themselves.
23 God does not need to examine anyone further
before bringing him to judgment.
24 He shatters the mighty without inquiry
and sets others in their place.

25 Because he knows what they do,
he overthrows them in the night, and they are crushed.
26 As wicked men he strikes them
in the place where all can see,[e]
27 because they turned aside from following him
and did not consider any of his ways,
28 so that they caused the cry of the poor to come to him,
and the cry of the afflicted he heard.
29 If he stays silent, who can condemn him?
If he hides his face, who can see him,
whether nation or individual alike?
30 that a godless man should not reign,
that there be no snares for the people.[f]
31 "For has a man ever said unto God,
'I bore my correction; no more will I transgress;
32 what I do not see, teach me;
if I have done iniquity, I will do it no more'?
33 Shall he repay on your terms, because you reject it?
For you must choose, and not I;
therefore speak what you know.
34 Men of understanding will tell me so,
and every sage who gives me a hearing:
35 'Job speaks without knowledge,
and his words are without insight.'
36 Would that Job were tried to the end,
because of his answers like men of iniquity!
37 For he adds rebellion to his sin;
he claps his hands[g] among us
and multiplies his words against God."

Notes

- a (34:6) Hebrew "my arrow," that is, the wound made by God's arrow (compare 6:4).
- b (34:10) That is, men of understanding; so also 34:34.
- c (34:13) Hebrew lacks "on him."
- d (34:14) Or "If he should set his mind on it"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (34:26) Hebrew "in the place of the onlookers."

- f (34:30) The Hebrew of verses 29–33 is very obscure.
- g (34:37) A gesture of scorn.

Chapter 35

1 Then Elihu answered and said:
2 “Do you count this to be just?
You say, ‘My righteousness is more than God’s,’
3 that you ask, ‘What advantage is it to you?[a]
What profit is mine more than if I had sinned?’
4 I will answer you with words,
and your friends with you.
5 Look to the heavens, and see;
and behold the clouds, which are higher than you.
6 Should you sin, how do you strike at him?
Be your rebellions many, what harm is that to him?
7 Be you just, what gift is that to him?
What does he take out of your hand?
8 To a man like you your wrongdoing reaches,
to a mortal your uprightness.
9 “Because of the multitude of oppressions they cry out;
they call for help because of the arm of the mighty.
10 Yet none asks, ‘Where is God who fashioned me,
who grants songs in the night season,
11 who teaches us more than the beasts of the earth,
and makes us wiser than the birds of the heavens?’
12 So they cry aloud, and he gives no reply,
by reason of the haughtiness of the evil.
13 Surely God does not hear an empty cry,
nor does Shaddai regard it.
14 How much the less when you claim you behold him not,
that your plea lies before him, and you wait upon him!
15 And now, since his wrath has not visited,
and he takes little note of folly,[b]
16 Job opens his mouth in vain;
he multiplies words without knowledge.”

Notes

- a (35:3) That is, to Job himself, "you" referring to himself in quoting his complaint; or, "to me."
- b (35:15) Hebrew pash, found only here; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "folly" or "transgression."

Chapter 36

1 And Elihu continued and said:
2 "Bear with me a little, and I will show you,
for there are yet words to say on God's behalf.
3 I will bring my knowledge from far away
and credit my Maker with justice.
4 For truly my words are not false;
one perfect in knowledge is with you.
5 "See, God is mighty, and does not despise any;
mighty in strength of heart.
6 The ungodly he lets not live,
but to the lowly he grants justice.
7 He does not withdraw his eyes from the righteous,
but with kings upon the throne
he seats them forever, and they are exalted.
8 Should they lie bound in chains,
held fast by the ropes of misery,
9 then he declares to them their work
and their transgressions, that they have behaved proudly.
10 He opens their ear to discipline
and commands that they return from iniquity.
11 If they obey and serve him,
they will finish their days in prosperity
and their years in pleasure.
12 But if they do not listen, they pass over by the javelin[a]
and breathe their last without knowledge.
13 "The godless in heart store up anger;
even when he binds them, they do not call for help.
14 Their soul dies in youth,
and their life among the cult prostitutes.[b]

15 He delivers the afflicted by his affliction
and opens their ear by oppression.
16 He drew you also from the jaws of trouble
to a wide place unhemmed,
and your table was laden with richness.[c]
17 But you are full of the judgment of the wicked;
judgment and justice take hold of you.
18 Take care lest fury lure you to mockery,
and let not a great bribe lead you astray.
19 Can your outcry set you beyond trouble,
or every effort of your might?
20 Do not long for the night,
when peoples are cut off in their place.
21 Watch yourself; turn not toward evil,
since that you prefer above affliction.
22 "See, God is exalted in his power;
who is a teacher like him?
23 Who has appointed him his way?
Or who can say, 'You have done wrong'?
24 Remember to magnify his work,
of which men have sung.
25 All mankind has looked upon it;
man beholds it from afar.
26 See, God is great, and we know him not;
the number of his years is past searching out.
27 For he draws up the drops of water;
they distill rain from his mist,
28 which the clouds pour down
and shower upon mankind abundantly.
29 Can anyone understand the spreading of the clouds,
the crashings of his pavilion?
30 See, he spreads his light about him
and covers the roots[d] of the sea.

31 For thereby he rules the nations;
plentiful food he bestows.
32 He covers his hands with the lightning
and commands it to strike the mark.
33 Its crashing declares concerning him;
the cattle also, concerning what rises.[e]

Notes

- a (36:12) Or "cross the river (of death)"; see the note at 33:18.
- b (36:14) Hebrew qedeshim, men who served as prostitutes at pagan shrines; the sense here is that their lives end in shame.
- c (36:16) The Hebrew of verses 16–20 is very obscure.
- d (36:30) Or "the depths."
- e (36:33) The Hebrew of this verse is very obscure. The Septuagint reads "The Lord will declare concerning this to his friend: but there is a portion also for unrighteousness" (Brenton).

Chapter 37

1 "Yes, at this my heart quakes
and springs up from its seat.
2 Hear, O hear the rumbling of his voice,
and the murmur that goes out from his mouth.
3 He sends it out under the whole sky,
and his lightning to the ends of the earth.
4 After that comes the sound of a roar;
he thunders with his majestic voice,
and he holds back none of the lightning[a] once his voice is heard.
5 God thunders wondrously with his voice;
he does great things, and we cannot know them.
6 For he bids the snow, 'Come down upon the earth,'
likewise the shower of rain, his torrents of strong rain.
7 He seals up the hand of every man,
that all men whom he made may know it.[b]
8 Then the beast goes into its lair
and remains in its dens.
9 Out of its chamber comes the storm,
and cold from the scattering winds.[c]

10 By the breath of God ice is given,
and the breadth of the waters is frozen fast.
11 He loads the thick cloud with moisture;
the cloud scatters his lightning.
12 They turn round and round by his guidance,
to do whatever he commands them
upon the face of the habitable world.
13 Whether for correction, or for his land,
or for steadfast love, he causes it to come.
14 "Give ear to this, O Job;
stand still and consider the wonders of God.
15 Know you how God charges them,
and makes the lightning of his cloud blaze out?
16 Do you know the balancings[d] of the clouds,
the wonders of him who is perfect in knowledge,
17 you whose clothes grow warm
when the land lies hushed beneath the south wind?
18 Can you join him in spreading out the sky,
hard as a mirror of cast metal?
19 Teach us what we shall say to him;
we cannot set our case in order because of darkness.
20 Should he be told I want to speak?
Would anyone ask to be swallowed up?
21 Now no one can look at the sun,
brilliant as it is in the sky,
once the wind has passed and swept the clouds away.
22 Out of the north comes golden splendor;[e]
about God is awesome majesty.
23 Shaddai—beyond our finding is he;
exalted in might;
and justice and plentiful uprightness he does not wrong.
24 Hence mortals hold him in awe;
none of the wise in heart does he regard."[f]

Notes

- a (37:4) Hebrew "them."
- b (37:7) Or "that all men may know his work"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (37:9) Hebrew mezarim, "scatterers," perhaps the north winds; uncertain.
- d (37:16) Hebrew miflese, found only here; perhaps "spreadings" or "balancings."
- e (37:22) Or "golden light." The Septuagint reads "From the north come the clouds shining like gold" (Brenton).
- f (37:24) Or "all the wise of heart cannot see him."

Chapter 38

1 Then Yahweh answered Job out of the whirlwind[a] and said:
2 "Who is this that darkens counsel
by words without knowledge?
3 Gird up now your loins like a man;[b]
I will question you, and you shall make it known to me.
4 "Where were you when I founded the earth?
Declare it, if you have understanding.
5 Who fixed its measurements—surely you know!
Or who stretched the line upon it?
6 Upon what were its footings settled,
or who set down its cornerstone,
7 when the morning stars sang together
and all the sons of God[c] shouted for joy?
8 "Or who shut in the sea with doors,
when it burst forth from the womb and went out,
9 when I made the cloud its garment
and thick darkness its swaddling band,
10 and broke for it my boundary
and set bars and doors,
11 and decreed, 'To here you may come, but not beyond;
here your swelling waves must halt'?
12 "Have you, in your days, commanded the morning,
or caused the dawn to know its place,
13 so that it grasps the edges of the earth
and shakes the wicked out of it?
14 It is changed like clay under the seal,
and things stand out like a garment.[d]

15 And from the wicked their light is withheld,
and the uplifted arm is broken.
16 “Have you entered into the springs of the sea,
or walked in the recesses of the deep?
17 Have the gates of death been revealed to you,
or have you seen the gates of deep darkness?
18 Have you comprehended the breadth of the earth?
Declare, if you know it all.
19 “Where is the way to where light dwells,
and darkness, where is its place,
20 that you might lead it to its border
and know the roads to its dwelling?
21 You know, for you were born then,
and the number of your days is great![e]
22 “Have you entered the storehouses of the snow,
or have you seen the storehouses of the hail,
23 which I have reserved for the time of distress,
for the day of battle and war?
24 By what way is the light[f] parted,
or the east wind scattered upon the earth?
25 “Who carved a course for the flooding rain,
a road for the thunder’s bolt,
26 to bring rain on a land where no man is,
on the wilderness in which there is no human being,
27 to satisfy the waste and desolate ground,
and to make the tender grass spring forth?
28 Is there a father for the rain?
Who sired the dewdrops?
29 From whose womb came the ice?
And the hoarfrost of heaven, who has given it birth?
30 The waters hide themselves as if turned to stone,
and the face of the deep is locked fast.
31 “Can you bind the bonds of the Pleiades,[g]
or loosen the cords of Orion?[h]

32 Can you lead forth the Mazzaroth[i] in its season,
or guide the Bear[j] with its children?
33 Do you know the statutes of the heavens?
Can you establish their rule upon the earth?
34 "Can you raise your voice to the clouds
so that a deluge of water covers you?
35 Can you send forth lightnings, that they may go
and say to you, 'Here we are'?
36 Who has put wisdom in the ibis,[k]
or given understanding to the rooster?
37 Who by wisdom counts the clouds?
Who tips over the jars of heaven,
38 when the dust runs into a mass
and the clods cleave fast together?
39 "Can you hunt the prey for the lion,
or satisfy the appetite of the young lions,
40 as they couch within their lairs,
or lurk in ambush in the thicket?
41 Who readies for the raven its prey,
when to God its nestlings call
and stray about without food?

Notes

- a (38:1) Or "storm."
- b (38:3) Or "like a warrior"; Hebrew gever.
- c (38:7) The Septuagint reads "all my angels praised me with a loud voice" (Brenton). See the note at 1:6.
- d (38:14) The image is of the dawn bringing the shapes of the earth into relief, as a seal impresses clay. The Septuagint reads very differently: "Or did you take clay of the ground, and form a living creature…?" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (38:21) Irony: Yahweh grants Job, in jest, the age of creation itself.
- f (38:24) Or "lightning."
- g (38:31) Hebrew kimah, a cluster of stars, generally identified as the Pleiades; Brenton's Septuagint has "Pleias." Compare 9:9.
- h (38:31) Hebrew kesil, "fool," generally identified as Orion, pictured as a giant bound in the sky. The identifications of these constellations are traditional, not certain.

- i (38:32) Hebrew mazzarot, found only here; perhaps the constellations of the zodiac, or a particular star or constellation (compare mazzalot, 2 Kings 23:5). The Septuagint keeps "Mazuroth" and adds "the evening star with his rays" (Brenton).
- j (38:32) Hebrew ʿayish, perhaps the Great Bear (Ursa Major) with its "children," the stars of its tail; others suggest Aldebaran or the Hyades. Compare 9:9.
- k (38:36) Hebrew tuḥot and sekhvi ("rooster") are both rare and uncertain; others render "in the inward parts… to the mind." The ibis (sacred to the Egyptian god of wisdom) and the rooster (heralding the dawn) were both regarded as weather-wise birds. The Septuagint reads "who has given to women skill in weaving, or knowledge of embroidery?" (Brenton).

Chapter 39

1 "Do you know the time when the mountain goats[a] give birth?
  Do you watch over the calving of the does?[b]
2 Can you reckon the months they complete,
  or know the season of their bearing,
3 when they crouch, bring forth their young,
  and cast out their labor pains?
4 Their young ones grow strong; they grow up in the open field;
  they go forth and do not return to them.
5 "Who sent out the wild donkey[c] free?
  Who has loosed the bonds of the swift donkey,
6 to whom I gave the steppe as dwelling,
  and the salt waste as his abode?
7 It scorns the noise of the town
  and does not hear a driver's shouts.
8 He ranges the mountains as his pasture
  and searches after every green thing.
9 "Will the wild ox[d] consent to be your servant?
  Will he lodge beside your feeding trough?
10 Can you bind the wild ox in the furrow with his rope?
  Or will he harrow the valleys after you?
11 Will you trust him because his strength is great,
  and leave to him your labor?
12 Will you trust him to haul in your seed
  and heap it upon your threshing floor?

13 “The ostrich[e] flaps its wings with joy,
but are its feathers and plumage like the stork’s?[f]
14 For she abandons her eggs upon the ground
and leaves them to warm in the dust,
15 forgetting that a foot may crush them,
and the wild beast trample them.
16 She deals harshly with her young, as if they were not hers;
though her labor be in vain, she has no fear,
17 since God has deprived her of wisdom
and allotted her no discernment.
18 When she rouses herself to flee aloft,[g]
she laughs at the horse and his rider.
19 “Is it you who grant the horse his strength?
Is it you who robe his neck with a mane?[h]
20 Do you make him leap like the locust?
The splendor of his snorting is terror.
21 It paws[i] the ground in the valley and rejoices in its power;
it charges out to face the weapons.
22 At fear he scoffs, undaunted;
from the sword he turns not away.
23 Upon him rattles the quiver,
the flashing spear and the javelin.
24 Quivering and raging he devours the distance;
when the horn blows he will not hold still.
25 At each blast of the horn he cries, ‘Hurrah!’
From far off he scents the fight,
the captains’ thunder and the battle cry.
26 “Does the hawk[j] take flight by your wisdom
and stretch his wings toward the southland?
27 Is it at your command that the eagle[k] mounts up
and makes his nest on high?
28 On the cliff he dwells and lodges,
on the tooth of the crag and the stronghold.

29 From there he spies out the prey;
his eyes behold it afar off.
30 His young ones also suck up blood,
and where the slain are, there is he."

Notes

- a (39:1) Hebrew yaʿale salaʿ, "climbers of the rock," probably the Nubian ibex. Brenton's Septuagint has "wild goats of the rock."
- b (39:1) Hebrew ʾayyalot, female deer; Brenton has "hinds."
- c (39:5) Hebrew pereʾ, and in the next line ʿarod (found only here in the Hebrew Bible), both names for the wild ass or onager, a swift, untamable desert animal.
- d (39:9) Hebrew reʾem, the aurochs or wild ox (now extinct), a powerful horned animal; the Septuagint has monokerōs, rendered "unicorn" by Brenton and other older English versions.
- e (39:13) Hebrew renanim, found only here, "cries" or "shrieking ones," generally taken as the ostrich, which fits the description that follows. The Septuagint reads "The peacock has a beautiful wing: if the stork and the ostrich conceive…" (Brenton). The identification is probable but not certain.
- f (39:13) Or "are they the pinions of the kindly one?" Hebrew ḥasidah (stork) sounds like ḥesed, "steadfast love." The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- g (39:18) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain.
- h (39:19) Hebrew raʿmah, found only here; perhaps "thunder," "quivering," or "a mane." Brenton's Septuagint has "terror."
- i (39:21) Hebrew "They paw."
- j (39:26) Hebrew nets, a falcon or hawk; the hawk's southward migration may be in view.
- k (39:27) Hebrew nesher, which can refer to the eagle or the griffon vulture; verse 30 suits the vulture.

Chapter 40

1 And Yahweh answered Job and said:
2 "Shall a faultfinder contend with Shaddai?
He who argues with God, let him answer it."
3 Then Job answered Yahweh and said:
4 "See, I am of small account; what shall I answer you?
My hand I lay upon my mouth.
5 Once I have spoken, and I will not answer;
twice, and I will proceed no further."
6 Then Yahweh answered Job out of the whirlwind and said:

7 “Gird up now your loins like a man;
I will question you, and you shall make it known to me.
8 Will you even annul my justice?
Will you condemn me, that you may be righteous?
9 Do you have an arm like God’s,
or a voice that thunders like his?
10 “Deck yourself now with majesty and dignity;
clothe yourself with splendor and honor.
11 Let loose the floods of your wrath;
behold each proud one, and bring him down.
12 Look on everyone who is proud, and bring him low,
and tread down the wicked where they stand.
13 Hide them in the dust together;
bind their faces in the hidden place.
14 Then I also will acknowledge to you
that your own right hand can save you.
15 “Behold now Behemoth,[a] whom I made along with you;
like cattle he feeds on grass.
16 See now, his strength is in his loins,
and his power in the muscles of his belly.
17 He stiffens his tail like a cedar;
the sinews of his thighs[b] are knit together.
18 His bones are tubes of bronze,
his limbs like bars of iron.
19 “It ranks first among God’s works;[c]
only its Maker can approach it with his sword.
20 For the mountains bring forth produce for him,
where all the beasts of the field play.
21 Under the lotus trees[d] he lies,
in the covert of the reed and the marsh.
22 The lotus trees cover him with their shade;
the willows of the brook surround him.
23 If the river surges, it is not alarmed;
it stays calm even if the Jordan[e] rushes up to its mouth.

24 Can he be seized while he watches,
or his snout be pierced with a trap?

Notes

- a (40:15) Hebrew behemot, the plural of behemah, "beast," used here as an intensive: "the Beast" par excellence. The description best suits the hippopotamus, though some see the elephant or a mythical creature. The Septuagint reads "But now look at the wild beasts with you" (Brenton, modernized). The identification is uncertain.
- b (40:17) Hebrew paḥad, here probably "thighs" (an Aramaic sense); found in this sense only here. Some take it as "testicles."
- c (40:19) Or "the chief of God's works." The Septuagint reads "This is the chief of the creation of the Lord; made to be played with by his angels" (Brenton).
- d (40:21) Hebrew tse'elim, found only here and in verse 22; probably the thorny lotus (Ziziphus lotus). Brenton's Septuagint has "trees of every kind, by the papyrus, and reed, and bulrush."
- e (40:23) That is, any great river in flood.

Chapter 41

1 "Can you draw out Leviathan[a] with a fishhook,[b]
or press down his tongue with a cord?
2 Can you put a rush rope in his nose,
or pierce his jaw with a hook?
3 Will he plead with you at length?
Will he address you gently?
4 Will he make a covenant with you,
that you take him for a servant forever?
5 Will you play with it as with a bird
or keep it on a leash for your girls?
6 Will partners haggle over him?
Will they parcel him out among the traders?
7 Can you stuff his hide with barbs,
or his skull with fish-spears?
8 Set your hand on him once;
think of the fight—you will do it no more!
9 "See, the hope of a man is disappointed;[c]
is he not laid low even at the sight of him?

10 No one is fierce enough to stir it up.
Who, then, can stand against me?
11 Who has given me something first, so that I must repay?[d]
Everything under all the heavens belongs to me.
12 "I will not stay silent about its limbs,
its great strength, or its graceful build.
13 Who can strip off his outer garment?
Who can come within his double coat of mail?[e]
14 Who can open the doors of his face?
Round about his teeth is terror.
15 His back is ranks of shields,[f]
sealed up tight together.
16 One is so near to another
that no air can come between them.
17 Each to its fellow is joined;
they grip one another and will not be parted.
18 His sneezings flash forth light,
and his eyes are like the eyelids of the dawn.[g]
19 From his mouth burning torches stream;
fiery sparks spring out.
20 From his nostrils smoke pours,
as from a seething pot over kindled reeds.
21 Its breath sets coals ablaze,
and flames shoot from its mouth.
22 In his neck abides strength,
and before him dances dismay.
23 The folds of its flesh are tightly joined,
firm on it and immovable.
24 His heart is firm as a stone,
firm as the nether millstone.
25 At his rising the mighty[h] take fright;
at the crashing they lose themselves.
26 The sword that strikes it is useless,
as are the spear, the dart, and the javelin.[i]

27 He counts iron as straw,
and bronze as rotten wood.
28 No arrow drives him off;
sling stones become chaff to him.
29 Clubs are counted as stubble;
he laughs at the rattle of the javelin.
30 Beneath him are jagged shards;
like a threshing sledge he sprawls in the mud.
31 He makes the deep boil like a pot;
he makes the sea like a pot of ointment.
32 It leaves a gleaming trail behind it;
you would think the deep had turned white-haired.
33 Upon earth there is not his like,
a creature made without fear.
34 He beholds everything that is high;
he is king over all the sons of pride."[j]

Notes

- a (41:1) Hebrew livyatan; see the note at 3:8. Here the description is often thought to draw on the crocodile, but it is enlarged with features of the mythic sea dragon (fire-breathing, verses 18–21), and the identification remains uncertain. The Hebrew and the Septuagint (Brenton) number 41:1–8 as 40:25–32, and 41:9–34 as 41:1–26. Brenton's Septuagint begins with the question whether one can catch the serpent with a hook (Brenton, modernized).
- b (41:1) Or "a hook."
- c (41:9) Hebrew "his hope is false," that is, the hope of anyone who would attack him.
- d (41:11) The Hebrew of verses 10–11 is difficult; some manuscripts and the Septuagint have a third-person sense, "who can stand before him… who has confronted him and come away safe?" (reported). Compare Romans 11:35.
- e (41:13) So the Septuagint, "who can enter within the fold of his breastplate?" (Brenton); the Hebrew reads "his double bridle," perhaps referring to the jaws.
- f (41:15) Or "His pride is his rows of shields." The Hebrew ga'avah, "pride," and gav, "back," differ by vowels only.
- g (41:18) The Septuagint reads "At his sneezing a light shines, and his eyes are as the appearance of the morning star" (Brenton).
- h (41:25) Or "the gods."
- i (41:26) Hebrew shiryah, found only here; perhaps "javelin" or "coat of mail."

- j (41:34) Hebrew bene-shaḥats, also at 28:8; probably the proud beasts of prey. The Septuagint reads “and he is king of all that are in the waters” (Brenton).

Chapter 42

1 Then Job answered Yahweh and said:
2 “I know that you can do all things,
and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted.
3 ‘Who is this that hides counsel without knowledge?’
Therefore I declared what I did not understand,
things too wonderful for me, which I did not know.
4 ‘Listen, and I will speak;
I will question you, and you will inform me.’
5 By the hearing of the ear I had heard of you,
but now my eye sees you;
6 therefore I despise myself,[a]
and I repent[b] upon dust and ashes.”
7 After Yahweh had said these things to Job, Yahweh said to Eliphaz the Temanite, “I am angry with you and your two friends, because you have not spoken what is right about me, as my servant Job has. 8 So now take seven bulls and seven rams for yourselves, and go to Job my servant, and offer up for yourselves a burnt offering. And Job my servant will intercede for you, for his prayer I will accept, so as not to treat you as your folly deserves; because you have not spoken rightly concerning me, as has Job my servant.” 9 So Eliphaz the Temanite and Bildad the Shuhite and Zophar the Naamathite went and did as Yahweh had told them, and Yahweh accepted Job.
10 And Yahweh turned the captivity[c] of Job when he prayed for his friends. And Yahweh gave to Job twice as much as all that he had before. 11 Then all his brothers and sisters and all his former acquaintances came to see him, and they shared a meal with him in his house. They felt sorry for him and consoled him over all the calamity that Yahweh had brought on him. Each one gave him a piece of money[d] and a gold ring.[e]
12 And Yahweh blessed the latter end of Job more than his beginning. And he had fourteen thousand sheep, and six thousand camels, and a

thousand yoke of oxen, and a thousand female donkeys. 13 He had also seven sons[f] and three daughters. 14 And he called the name of the first Jemimah,[g] and the name of the second Keziah,[h] and the name of the third Keren-happuch.[i] 15 And in all the land no women were found so fair as the daughters of Job. And their father gave them an inheritance among their brothers. 16 And after this Job lived a hundred and forty years,[j] and saw his sons, and his sons' sons, four generations. 17 And Job died, old and full of days.[k]

Notes

- a (42:6) Or "I reject (my words)," or "I melt away"; the Hebrew verb has no stated object. The Septuagint reads "Wherefore I have counted myself vile, and have fainted" (Brenton). This verse is a well-known crux.
- b (42:6) Or "I am comforted," or "I relent concerning dust and ashes," that is, concerning my mortal condition or my mourning. The Hebrew niḥamti can bear several senses.
- c (42:10) Or "restored the fortunes."
- d (42:11) Hebrew qesitah, a unit of money or weight of unknown value, found elsewhere only in Genesis 33:19 and Joshua 24:32; the Septuagint has "a lamb" (Brenton), and some ancient versions also take it as a lamb. The Qumran Aramaic Targum of Job (11QtgJob) is reported to end in this verse.
- e (42:11) Or "a nose ring" or "earring." The Septuagint reads "four drachms' weight of gold, even of unstamped gold" (Brenton).
- f (42:13) The Hebrew form shivʿanah is unusual; some Jewish interpreters took it to mean "twice seven," that is, fourteen sons.
- g (42:14) Jemimah probably means "dove"; the Septuagint has "Day" (Brenton).
- h (42:14) Keziah means "cassia," a fragrant spice; the Septuagint has "Casia" (Brenton).
- i (42:14) Keren-happuch means "horn of eye-paint," a container for the cosmetic used to darken the eyelids; the Septuagint has "Amalthæa's horn" (Brenton), the horn of plenty.
- j (42:16) The Septuagint reads "And Job lived after his affliction a hundred and seventy years: and all the years he lived were two hundred and forty" (Brenton).
- k (42:17) The Septuagint adds a long postscript (Brenton, modernized): "And it is written that he will rise again with those whom the Lord raises up. This man is described in the Syriac book as living in the land of Ausis, on the borders of Idumea and Arabia, and his name before was Jobab. And having taken an Arabian wife, he fathered a son whose name was Ennon. And he himself was the son of his father Zare, one of the sons of Esau, and of his mother Bosorrha, so that he was the fifth from Abraham. And these were the kings who reigned in Edom, which country he also ruled over: first, Balac the son of Beor, and the name of his

city was Dennaba; and after Balac, Jobab, who is called Job; and after him Asom, who was governor out of the country of Thaeman; and after him Adad the son of Barad, who destroyed Madiam in the plain of Moab, and the name of his city was Gethaim. And his friends who came to him were Eliphaz, of the children of Esau, king of the Thaemanites; Baldad, sovereign of the Sauchaeans; Sophar, king of the Minaeans." This addition identifies Job with Jobab of Genesis 36:33 and is not part of the Hebrew text.

Psalms

Old Testament

Chapter 1

Book One (Psalms 1–41)

1 Blessed is the man[a]
who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked,
nor stand in the way of sinners,
nor sit in the seat of scoffers;
2 but his delight is in the law[b] of Yahweh,
and on his law he meditates[c] day and night.
3 He will be like a tree planted beside streams of water,
which yields its fruit in its time;
its leaf also does not wither,
and whatever he does prospers.
4 Not so the wicked!
They are like the chaff that the wind drives away.
5 Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment,
nor sinners in the assembly of the righteous.
6 For Yahweh knows the way of the righteous,
but the way of the wicked will perish.

Notes

- a (1:1) Or "Happy is the one." Hebrew 'ashre, "O the happiness of," opens Psalm 1 and closes Psalm 2 (2:12), so that the two psalms frame an introduction to the whole Psalter. "The man" here stands for any person who lives this way.
- b (1:2) Hebrew torah, "instruction, teaching": God's word as a whole, not only the commandments.
- c (1:2) Hebrew hagah, to murmur or recite in a low voice; reading aloud and pondering.

Chapter 2

1 Why do the nations rage,[a]
and the peoples mutter empty plans?

2 The kings of the earth take their stand,
and the rulers plot together
against Yahweh and against his anointed one:[b]
3 "Let us tear their bonds apart,
and cast their ropes away from us!"
4 The One enthroned in the heavens laughs;
the Lord[c] mocks them.
5 Then he will speak to them in his anger,
and terrify them in his fury:
6 "But I—I have set my king
on Zion, my holy mountain."
7 I will tell of the decree:
Yahweh said to me, "You are my son;
today I have become your father.[d]
8 Ask it of me, and I will give you the nations for your heritage,
and the farthest ends of the earth for your own.
9 You will break them with a rod of iron;[e]
you will smash them like a potter's jar."
10 Now therefore, you kings, be wise;
be warned, you judges of the earth.
11 Serve Yahweh with fear,
and rejoice with trembling.
12 Kiss the son,[f] lest he be angry and you perish on the way,
for his anger is quickly kindled.
Blessed are all who take refuge in him.

Notes

- a (2:1) Or "gather in tumult." Acts 4:25–26 quotes verses 1–2 from the Greek.
- b (2:2) Hebrew mashiakh, "anointed one," the king anointed with oil; the word from which "Messiah" comes. The New Testament reads this psalm of Christ (Acts 13:33; Hebrews 1:5; 5:5).
- c (2:4) Hebrew Adonai, "Lord, Master," a title of God distinct from the divine name Yahweh. It is rendered "Lord" throughout this translation.
- d (2:7) Hebrew "I have begotten you," the language of the king's installation as God's son (compare 2 Samuel 7:14).

- e (2:9) The Septuagint, reading the same consonants with other vowels, has "You will shepherd them with a rod of iron," the form quoted in Revelation 2:27; 12:5; 19:15.
- f (2:12) The Hebrew is difficult. "Son" here is bar, the Aramaic word (Hebrew uses ben, as in verse 7). Some take the line as "Kiss purely," or "Do homage in purity"; the Septuagint has "Take hold of instruction," and the Latin Vulgate (Jerome) "Embrace discipline," though Jerome elsewhere rendered "worship purely." Kissing the hand or feet was a sign of submission to a king.

Chapter 3

A psalm of David, when he fled from Absalom his son.

1 Yahweh, how many enemies I have!
So many stand against me,
2 many are saying of my soul,
"There is no salvation for him in God."
Selah[b]
3 But you, Yahweh, are a shield around me,
my glory, and the one who lifts up my head.
4 With my voice I cry to Yahweh,
and he answers me from his holy mountain.
Selah
5 I lay down and slept;
I woke, for Yahweh sustains me.
6 I will not be afraid of ten thousands of people
who have set themselves against me all around.
7 Arise, Yahweh! Save me, my God!
For you have struck all my enemies on the jaw;
you have shattered the teeth of the wicked.
8 Salvation belongs to Yahweh;
your blessing be upon your people!
Selah

Notes

- a (3 title) See 2 Samuel 15–18. In the Hebrew Bible a psalm's title is counted as verse 1 (or verses 1–2), so the Hebrew verse numbers of titled psalms usually run one higher than the English numbers used here.
- b (3:2) Selah occurs 71 times in the Psalms and three times in Habakkuk 3. Its meaning is unknown; it is probably a musical or liturgical direction, perhaps

calling for a pause, an interlude, or a raising of the voice. The Septuagint renders it diapsalma, "interlude."

Chapter 4

For the choir leader: with stringed instruments. A psalm of David.

1 Answer me when I call, my righteous God!
When I was in trouble, you gave me room;[c]
have mercy on me and listen to my prayer.
2 You sons of men,[d] how long will my honor be turned to shame?
How long will you love emptiness and seek after lies?
Selah
3 Know that Yahweh has set apart the faithful one[e] for himself;
Yahweh hears when I call to him.
4 Tremble,[f] and do not sin;
speak within your hearts on your beds, and be still.
Selah
5 Offer sacrifices of righteousness,
and put your trust in Yahweh.
6 Many are asking, "Who will let us see something good?"
Yahweh, lift the light of your face over us.
7 You have put gladness in my heart,
more than when their grain and new wine abound.
8 I will lie down in peace and fall asleep,
for you alone, Yahweh, keep me living securely.

Notes

- a (4 title) Hebrew lamnatseakh, perhaps "for the leader," "for the director of music"; it heads 55 psalms. The Septuagint takes it as "for the end."
- b (4 title) Hebrew neginot.
- c (4:1) Hebrew "you made room for me."
- d (4:2) Or "You people of rank"; Hebrew bene 'ish, which may mean men of standing.
- e (4:3) Hebrew khasid, one devoted to God and loyal in covenant love (khesed).
- f (4:4) Or "Be angry." The Septuagint has "Be angry, and do not sin," quoted in Ephesians 4:26.

Chapter 5

For the choir leader: for the flutes. A psalm of David.

1 Give ear to my words, Yahweh;
consider my sighing.[b]
2 Listen to the sound of my cry, my King and my God,
for to you I pray.
3 Yahweh, in the morning you hear my voice;
in the morning I lay my case before you[c] and keep watch.
4 For you are not a God who takes pleasure in wickedness;
evil cannot dwell with you.
5 The arrogant cannot stand in your sight;
you hate all who do evil.
6 You destroy those who speak lies;
the man of bloodshed and deceit Yahweh abhors.
7 But as for me, by the greatness of your covenant love[d] I will come into your house;
in awe of you I will bow down toward your holy temple.
8 Yahweh, because of my enemies who watch for me, guide me in your righteousness;
level your road in front of me.
9 For there is no truth in their mouth;
within them is ruin;
their throat is a grave left open;
with their tongue they speak smoothly.[e]
10 Hold them guilty, O God;
let them fall by their own schemes.
For their many transgressions thrust them out,
for they have rebelled against you.
11 But let all who shelter in you be glad;
let them sing for joy forever, and cover them,
that the lovers of your name may exult in you.
12 For you bless the righteous, Yahweh;
you surround him with favor as with a shield.

Notes

- a (5 title) Hebrew nekhilot, probably "flutes"; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (5:1) Or "my murmuring," "my meditation."

- c (5:3) Or "I prepare a sacrifice for you"; the verb is used of setting out an offering or arranging words.
- d (5:7) Hebrew khesed, God's loyal, covenant-keeping love and kindness; a key word of the Psalms (it occurs about 130 times), rendered "covenant love" in this translation.
- e (5:9) Paul quotes this line in Romans 3:13.

Chapter 6

For the choir leader: with stringed instruments, on the eighth. A psalm of David.

1 Yahweh, do not correct me in anger
or punish me in fury.
2 Be gracious to me, Yahweh, for I am languishing;
heal me, Yahweh, for my bones are shaken.
3 My soul also is greatly shaken;
but you, Yahweh—how long?
4 Turn, Yahweh, rescue my soul;
save me because of your covenant love.
5 No one in death remembers you;
in the grave[b] who can praise you?
6 I am weary with my groaning;
every night I flood my bed;
I drench my couch with my tears.
7 My eye is wasted with sorrow;
it has grown old because of all my adversaries.
8 Depart from me, all you workers of iniquity,
for Yahweh has heard the sound of my weeping.
9 Yahweh has heard my plea;
Yahweh accepts my prayer.
10 All my enemies will be ashamed and greatly shaken;
they will turn back and be put to shame in a moment.

Notes

- a (6 title) Hebrew 'al hasheminit, perhaps an instrument of eight strings, or a lower octave; the meaning is uncertain. This is the first of seven psalms that the church has long called the Penitential Psalms (6, 32, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143).
- b (6:5) Sheol is the Hebrew name for the realm of the dead, the grave or underworld.

Chapter 7

A shiggaion of David, which he sang to Yahweh concerning the words of Cush, a Benjaminite.

1 Yahweh my God, in you I take refuge;
save me from all who pursue me, and deliver me,
2 lest like a lion they tear my soul apart,
dragging me off, with none to deliver.
3 Yahweh my God, if I have done this,
if there is wrong in my hands,
4 if I have paid back evil to the one at peace with me,
or stripped my adversary without cause,
5 let the enemy pursue my soul and overtake it,
and trample my life to the ground,
and lay my glory in the dust.
Selah
6 Rise up, Yahweh, in your anger;
stand tall against the rage of my enemies;
wake up on my behalf;[c] you have ordered justice.
7 Let the assembly of the peoples gather around you,
and over it return on high.
8 Yahweh is the judge of the nations;
vindicate me, Yahweh, as my righteousness deserves,
and by the innocence I have.
9 Let the evil of the wicked come to an end,
but establish the righteous—
you who test hearts and minds,[d] O righteous God.
10 My shield is with God,
who saves the upright in heart.
11 God is a righteous judge,
and a God who is indignant every day.
12 If a man does not repent, God will sharpen his sword;
he has bent his bow and made it ready.
13 He has prepared for himself weapons of death;
he makes his arrows fiery shafts.

14 Look, the wicked man conceives iniquity;
he is pregnant with mischief and gives birth to lies.
15 He digs a pit and scoops it out,
and falls himself into the hole he made.
16 His mischief returns upon his own head,
and his violence comes down on his own skull.
17 I will give thanks to Yahweh for his righteousness,
and I will sing praise to the name of Yahweh, the Most High.[e]

Notes

- a (7 title) Hebrew shiggayon, a term of uncertain meaning, perhaps a lament or an impassioned song (compare Habakkuk 3:1).
- b (7 title) Cush is otherwise unknown; perhaps an ally of Saul from Saul's tribe of Benjamin.
- c (7:6) Or "awake, my God"; the Septuagint has "awake, O Lord my God."
- d (7:9) Hebrew "hearts and kidneys," the seat of thought and of the deepest feelings.
- e (7:17) Hebrew Elyon, "Most High," a title of God (compare Genesis 14:18–22).

Chapter 8

For the choir leader: on the gittith. A psalm of David.

1 Yahweh, our Lord,[b]
how majestic is your name in all the earth!
You have set your splendor above the heavens.[c]
2 Out of the mouths of children and infants
you have founded strength because of your foes,
to silence the enemy and the avenger.[d]
3 When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers,
the moon and the stars, which you have set in place,
4 what is a human being, that you think of him,
and the son of man,[e] that you look after him?
5 Yet you have made him only a little less than God,[f]
and with glory and honor you crown him.
6 You make him ruler over the works of your hands;
you have put all things under his feet:
7 sheep and oxen, all of them,
and also the beasts of the field,

[8] the birds of the sky and the fish of the sea,
all that travel the paths of the seas.
[9] Yahweh, our Lord,
how majestic is your name in all the earth!

Notes

- a (8 title) Hebrew 'al haggittit, perhaps an instrument or tune from Gath, or a song for the winepress (Hebrew gat); the meaning is uncertain.
- b (8:1) Here "Lord" is Hebrew 'adon, "master, sovereign," the ordinary word for a lord, used here of God.
- c (8:1) The Hebrew of this line is difficult; literally perhaps "which, give your splendor upon the heavens."
- d (8:2) The Septuagint has "you have prepared praise," the form quoted in Matthew 21:16.
- e (8:4) Or "what is a human being… and a mortal." Hebrew 'enosh and ben 'adam are both words for humankind. Hebrews 2:6–8 reads verses 4–6 of Jesus.
- f (8:5) Hebrew 'elohim, which can mean God or heavenly beings; the Septuagint has "angels," as quoted in Hebrews 2:7.

Chapter 9

For the choir leader: on Muth-labben. A psalm of David.

[1] I will give thanks to Yahweh with my whole heart;
I will recount all your wonderful deeds.
[2] I will be glad and exult in you;
I will sing praise to your name, O Most High.
[3] When my enemies turn back,
they stumble and perish before you.
[4] For you have maintained my right and my cause;
you sit on the throne, a righteous judge.
[5] You have rebuked the nations; you have destroyed the wicked;
you have blotted out their name forever and ever.
[6] The enemy has come to an end in ruins forever;
you have uprooted their cities;
the very memory of them has perished.
[7] But Yahweh is seated as king forever;
he has set up his throne for judgment.
[8] And he will judge the world in righteousness;
he will judge the peoples with equity.

9 Yahweh will be a high refuge for the crushed,
a high refuge in times of distress.
10 And those who know your name will trust in you,
for you, Yahweh, have not forsaken those who seek you.
11 Sing praises to Yahweh, who dwells in Zion!
Tell among the peoples his deeds!
12 For the one who requires blood remembers them;
he has not forgotten the outcry of the humble.[b]
13 Have mercy on me, Yahweh!
Look at how my haters make me suffer;
you raise me up from the gates of death,
14 that I may recount all your praises,
in the gates of the daughter of Zion[c]
I will rejoice in your salvation.
15 The nations have sunk down into the pit they dug;
their own foot is caught in the net they hid.
16 Yahweh has made himself known; he has executed judgment;
the wicked is snared in the work of his own hands.
Higgaion.[d] Selah
17 The wicked shall turn back to Sheol,
all the nations who forget God.
18 For the needy will not always be forgotten,
nor the hope of the afflicted[e] perish forever.
19 Arise, Yahweh! Let not man prevail;
let the nations be judged before you.
20 Put them in fear, Yahweh;
let the nations know that they are but men.
Selah

Notes

- a (9 title) Hebrew 'al-mut labben, perhaps "on the death of the son," the name of a tune; the meaning is uncertain. Psalms 9 and 10 together form a single acrostic poem, each pair of verses beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, though the pattern is broken in places. Psalm 10 has no title, and the Septuagint and Vulgate treat 9–10 as one psalm (their Psalm 9); from there until Psalm 147 their numbering runs one behind the Hebrew (see the note on the numbering at the end of the book).

- b (9:12) So the qere; the ketiv has “the afflicted.” The two Hebrew words, ʿaniyyim and ʿanawim, are often interchanged in the Psalms.
- c (9:14) That is, the city of Jerusalem, pictured as a young woman.
- d (9:16) Hebrew higgayon, perhaps a musical interlude or a meditative murmur (compare 19:14; 92:3).
- e (9:18) So the qere; the ketiv has “the humble.”

Chapter 10

1 Why, Yahweh, do you stand far off?
Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?
2 The wicked in their pride chase down the poor;
may they be trapped by the plots they have made.
3 For the wicked boasts of the desire of his soul,
and the greedy one curses and spurns Yahweh.[a]
4 In his haughtiness the wicked does not seek him;
“There is no God” is the sum of all his schemes.
5 His ways are firm at all times;
your judgments are high above, out of his sight;
he scoffs at all his adversaries.
6 He says in his heart, “I will not be moved;
throughout all generations I will not meet adversity.”
7 His mouth is full of cursing and deceit and oppression;[b]
under his tongue are mischief and iniquity.
8 He sits in ambush near the villages;
in secret places he kills the innocent;
his eyes spy out the helpless.
9 He lies in wait in secret like a lion in his thicket;
he lies in wait to seize the afflicted;
he seizes the afflicted when he draws him into his net.
10 He crouches, he bows down,
and the helpless fall by his might.[c]
11 He says in his heart, “God has forgotten;
he has hidden his face; he will never see it.”
12 Arise, Yahweh! O God, raise your hand;
do not forget the lowly.[d]

13 Why do the wicked reject God
and tell themselves, "You will not hold me accountable"?
14 But you have seen it, for you observe trouble and sorrow,
and take it in hand;
the helpless entrusts himself to you;
you have always helped the orphan.
15 Break the arm of the wicked and evil person;
search out his evil until nothing of it is left.
16 Yahweh is King forever and ever;
the nations have perished from his land.
17 Yahweh, you have heard the longing of the meek;
you will make their hearts firm and turn your ear to them
18 to give justice to the orphan and the crushed,
so that mortals made from the earth will never again strike terror.

Notes

- a (10:3) Or "and blesses the greedy one, and spurns Yahweh." The Hebrew is uncertain; "curses" translates "blesses," which may be a scribal euphemism.
- b (10:7) Paul quotes this line in Romans 3:14.
- c (10:10) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- d (10:12) So the qere; the ketiv has "the afflicted."

Chapter 11

For the choir leader. Of David.

1 I take refuge in Yahweh.
How can you tell me,
"Fly away[b] to your mountain like a bird"?
2 Look, the wicked draw their bows;
they have fitted their arrows to the strings
to shoot from the shadows at people with honest hearts.
3 When the foundations are torn down,
what can the righteous do?
4 Yahweh is in his holy temple;
Yahweh—his throne is in the heavens;
his eyes behold, his eyelids examine the children of man.

5 Yahweh puts the righteous to the test,
but the wicked and the lover of violence his soul hates.
6 On the wicked he will rain snares;[c]
fire and sulfur and a scorching wind will be the portion of their cup.
7 For Yahweh is righteous and loves acts of righteousness;
the upright shall gaze upon his face.

Notes

- a (11 title) Or "By David," "For David," or "Belonging to David." The Hebrew preposition le- in the titles can mark authorship, dedication, or a collection associated with David.
- b (11:1) So the qere; the ketiv has a plural verb, "Flee, you people."
- c (11:6) Or, with a slight change, "coals of fire."

Chapter 12

For the choir leader: on the eighth. A psalm of David.

1 Save, Yahweh, for the godly one is no more;
the faithful have vanished from among the children of man.
2 Each one speaks falsehood with his neighbor;
with smooth lips and a double heart they speak.
3 May Yahweh cut off all smooth lips,
the tongue that talks of great things,
4 those who say, "By our tongue we shall be strong;
our lips are with us—who is lord over us?"
5 "Because the afflicted are plundered, because the needy groan,
now I will arise," says Yahweh;
"I will set him in the safety for which he longs."[a]
6 The words of Yahweh are pure words,
silver refined in a furnace on the ground,[b]
purified seven times.
7 You, Yahweh, will protect them;
you will keep them[c] safe from this generation forever.
8 On every side the wicked prowl,
when vileness is exalted among the children of man.

Notes

- a (12:5) Or "that he pants for"; or "from the one who puffs at him." The Hebrew is uncertain.

- b (12:6) The meaning of the Hebrew phrase is uncertain.
- c (12:7) Or “guard us” (so some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint).

Chapter 13

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever?
How long will you hide your face from me?
2 How long must I take counsel in my soul,
with sorrow in my heart all the day?
How long shall my enemy be exalted over me?
3 Look on me and answer me, Yahweh my God;
give light to my eyes, lest I sleep the sleep of death,
4 lest my enemy say, “I have overcome him,”
lest my foes rejoice because I am shaken.
5 But as for me, I have trusted in your covenant love;
my heart shall rejoice in your salvation.
6 I will sing to Yahweh,
because he has dealt generously with me.

Chapter 14

For the choir leader. Of David.

1 The fool[b] has said in his heart, “There is no God.”
They act corruptly; their deeds are detestable;
not one of them does good.
2 Yahweh looks down from heaven on the children of man,
to see whether there is anyone who understands,
anyone who seeks after God.
3 All have gone astray; all alike have turned rotten;
no one does good,
no, not one.[c]
4 Do all the workers of iniquity have no knowledge,
who eat up my people as they eat bread,
and do not call upon Yahweh?
5 There they shall be in terror, terror indeed,
for God is in the company of the righteous.

6 You would put to shame the plans of the afflicted,
but Yahweh is his refuge.
7 Oh, that the salvation of Israel would come out of Zion!
When Yahweh restores the fortunes of his people,
let Jacob rejoice, let Israel be glad.

Notes

- a (14 title) Psalm 14 appears again, with small differences, as Psalm 53, where God (Elohim) stands in place of Yahweh.
- b (14:1) Hebrew nabal, one who is morally and spiritually senseless, not merely unintelligent (compare Nabal in 1 Samuel 25:25).
- c (14:3) Paul quotes verses 1–3 in Romans 3:10–12. Some Septuagint manuscripts add here the lines that Paul quotes in Romans 3:13–18.

Chapter 15

A psalm of David.

1 Yahweh, who may sojourn in your tent?
Who may dwell on your holy mountain?
2 The one who walks blamelessly and does what is right,
and speaks truth in his heart;
3 who does not slander with his tongue,
nor does evil to his companion,
nor takes up a reproach against his neighbor;
4 who despises those who are vile in his eyes
but gives honor to those who fear Yahweh;
who keeps his promise even when it hurts him;
5 who does not lend his money at interest,[a]
nor take a bribe against the innocent.
He who does these things shall never be moved.

Notes

- a (15:5) Lending at interest to a fellow Israelite in need was forbidden by the law (Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:35–37; Deuteronomy 23:19–20).

Chapter 16

A miktam of David.

1 Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge.

2 I said[b] to Yahweh, "You are my Lord;
I have no good apart from you."
3 As for the saints who are in the land,
they are the majestic ones, and all my delight is in them.[c]
4 The sorrows of those who hurry after another god shall be multiplied;
I will not pour out their drink offerings of blood,
nor take their names upon my lips.
5 Yahweh is my allotted portion and my cup;
you hold fast my lot.
6 My measured portion has fallen to me in lovely places;
indeed, my heritage is beautiful to me.
7 I will bless Yahweh, who gives me counsel;
even in the nights my inmost being[d] instructs me.
8 I have set Yahweh always before me;
because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.
9 So my heart rejoices and my glory[e] is glad;
my body too shall rest secure.
10 For you will not leave my soul in the grave
or let your loyal one[f] see the pit.[g]
11 You make me know the path of life;
with your face there is joy in full;
at your right hand, delights forever.

Notes

- a (16 title) Hebrew miktam, a term of uncertain meaning, used in the titles of Psalms 16 and 56–60; perhaps "inscription" or "epigram."
- b (16:2) So the Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts; most Hebrew manuscripts have "You said," addressed to the soul.
- c (16:3) The Hebrew of verses 3 and 4 is difficult, and the sense is uncertain.
- d (16:7) Hebrew "my kidneys."
- e (16:9) Or "my soul"; the Septuagint has "my tongue," as quoted in Acts 2:26.
- f (16:10) So the qere and many Hebrew manuscripts, with the ancient versions; the ketiv has "your faithful ones."
- g (16:10) Or "see corruption." The Septuagint has "corruption," the form quoted in Acts 2:27 and 13:35, where Peter and Paul apply verses 8–11 to the resurrection of Jesus.

Chapter 17

A prayer of David.

1 Hear my just cause, Yahweh; attend to my cry!
Give ear to my prayer, which comes from honest lips!
2 Let my sentence go out from before you;
may your eyes see the things that are right.
3 You have probed my heart and examined me in the night;
you have refined me and found no wrong;
I have purposed that my mouth shall not overstep.
4 As for the deeds of men, by the word of your lips
I have kept myself from the ways of the violent.
5 My steps have held fast to your paths;
my feet have not slipped.
6 I call upon you, for you will answer me, O God;
incline your ear to me; hear my words.
7 Show the wonders of your covenant love,
you who save by your right hand
those who seek refuge from their adversaries.
8 Keep me as the pupil of the eye;[a]
hide me in the shadow of your wings
9 from the wicked who assault me,
my deadly enemies who surround me.
10 They have closed up their unfeeling heart;[b]
with their mouth they speak arrogantly.
11 They have tracked us down; now they have surrounded us;[c]
they set their eyes to cast us to the ground.
12 He is like a lion that longs to rend its prey,
like a young lion crouching in secret places.
13 Arise, Yahweh, confront him, bring him down!
Deliver my soul from the wicked by your sword,
14 from men by your hand, Yahweh,
from men of the world whose portion is in this life.
You fill their belly with what you have stored up;[d]

their sons are satisfied,
and they leave what remains to their little ones.
15 But I, in righteousness I shall see your face;
when I wake, your form will satisfy me.

Notes

- a (17:8) Hebrew "as the little man, the daughter of the eye," referring to the small reflection one sees in another's pupil.
- b (17:10) Hebrew "their fat."
- c (17:11) So the qere; the ketiv has "surrounded me."
- d (17:14) So the qere ("your treasured things"); the ketiv has a different spelling of the same word. The sense of the verse is uncertain: it may describe the punishment stored up for the wicked, or the good things God gives his own.

Chapter 18

For the choir leader. Of David the servant of Yahweh, who spoke to Yahweh the words of this song on the day when Yahweh delivered him from the hand of all his enemies and from the hand of Saul. He said:

1 I love you, Yahweh, my strength.[b]
2 Yahweh is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer,
my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge,
my shield, and the horn[c] of my salvation, my high tower.
3 I call upon Yahweh, who is worthy to be praised,
and I am saved from my enemies.
4 The ropes of death wrapped around me;
the floods of destruction[d] overwhelmed me with terror;
5 the ropes of Sheol coiled about me;
the traps of death came upon me.
6 In my distress I called on Yahweh,
and to my God I cried out;
he heard my voice out of his temple,
and my cry for help before him reached his ears.
7 Then the earth shook and trembled;
the roots of the mountains quaked
and were shaken, for his anger blazed.

8 Smoke rose from his nostrils,
and fire from his mouth consumed;
coals were kindled by it.
9 He bowed the heavens and came down;
thick darkness was under his feet.
10 He rode on a cherub and flew;
he soared on the wings of the wind.
11 He made darkness his covering, his canopy around him,
dark waters, thick clouds of the skies.
12 Out of the brightness in front of him
his dense clouds moved on,
with hail and burning coals.
13 Yahweh also thundered in the heavens,
and the Most High uttered his voice,
hailstones and coals of fire.[e]
14 He shot his arrows and scattered them;[f]
lightning bolts he hurled and threw them into confusion.
15 Then the channels of water were seen,
and the foundations of the world were laid bare
at your rebuke, Yahweh,
at the blast of the breath of your nostrils.
16 He reached down from on high, he took me;
he drew me out of many waters.
17 He delivered me from my strong enemy,
and from those who hated me, for they were too mighty for me.
18 They confronted me in the day of my calamity,
but Yahweh was my support.
19 He led me out into a wide, open place;
he rescued me because he took pleasure in me.
20 Yahweh dealt with me according to my righteousness;
according to the cleanness of my hands he repaid me.
21 For I have kept the ways of Yahweh,
and have not wickedly departed from my God.

22 For all his judgments were before me,
and his statutes I did not put away from me.
23 I was without fault before him,
and I kept myself from wrongdoing.
24 So Yahweh has repaid me according to my righteousness,
according to the cleanness of my hands in his sight.
25 To the loyal you show yourself loyal;
to the man of integrity you show yourself whole;
26 to the pure you prove yourself pure,
but to the twisted you prove yourself crafty.
27 For a lowly people you save,
but proud eyes you humble.
28 For you light my lamp;
Yahweh my God lights up my darkness.
29 For by you I rush upon a raiding band,
and by my God I leap over a rampart.
30 This God—his way is blameless;
the word of Yahweh is tested;
he is a shield to all who take refuge in him.
31 For who is God, except Yahweh?
And who is a rock, except our God?—
32 It is God who wraps me in strength
and makes my path without fault.
33 He makes my feet like a doe's feet
and makes me stand firm on the heights.
34 He teaches my hands to fight,
and my arms can draw a bow of bronze.
35 You have given me the shield of your salvation,
and your right hand has upheld me,
and your gentleness[g] has made me great.
36 You have widened the ground beneath my steps,
and my ankles have not slipped.
37 I chased my enemies and caught up with them;
I did not turn around till I had finished them.

38 I struck them through, so that they could not rise;
they fell under my feet.
39 You wrapped me in strength for the fight;
you made my attackers kneel beneath me.
40 You made my enemies show me their backs,
and I wiped out those who hated me.
41 They cried for help, but there was none to save;
they cried to Yahweh, but he did not answer them.
42 I ground them like dust before the wind;
I poured them out like mire in the streets.
43 You rescued me from the quarrels of the people;
you set me at the head of nations;
a people I did not know became my servants.
44 At the mere report of me they submit;
sons of foreigners come fawning to me.
45 The sons of foreigners wither away
and come quaking from their fortresses.
46 Yahweh lives! Blessed be my rock,
and exalted be the God of my salvation—
47 the God who gives me vengeance
and subdues peoples under me,
48 who delivers me from my enemies;
yes, you lift me up above those who rise against me;
you rescue me from the man of violence.
49 Therefore I will give thanks to you among the nations, Yahweh,
and sing praises to your name.[h]
50 Great salvation he gives[i] to his king,
and shows covenant love to his anointed,
to David and to his offspring forever.

Notes

- a (18 title) This psalm appears also, with many small differences, in 2 Samuel 22.
- b (18:1) This line is not found in 2 Samuel 22.
- c (18:2) The horn, the weapon and pride of a strong animal, is a picture of strength and victory.

- d (18:4) Hebrew beliyya'al, "worthlessness," here perhaps a name for the underworld.
- e (18:13) This line is lacking in 2 Samuel 22:14, in some Hebrew manuscripts, and in the Septuagint; it may have been repeated from verse 12.
- f (18:14) That is, the enemies.
- g (18:35) Or "your humility," that is, your stooping down; or, as in 2 Samuel 22:36, "your answering."
- h (18:49) Paul quotes this verse in Romans 15:9.
- i (18:50) So the qere; the ketiv has "He is a tower of salvation," as in the qere of 2 Samuel 22:51.

Chapter 19

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 The heavens declare the glory of God,
and the sky[a] announces what his hands have made.
2 Each day gushes forth speech to the next,
and each night makes knowledge known to the next.
3 There is no speaking and there are no words;
no voice of theirs is heard.
4 Yet their line goes out into all the earth,[b]
and their sayings to the farthest edge of the world.
There he has pitched a tent for the sun,
5 and it is like a bridegroom coming out of his canopy;
like a champion it rejoices to run its path.
6 Its rising is from the end of the heavens,
and its circuit to their other end,
and there is nothing hidden from its heat.
7 The law of Yahweh is perfect, restoring the soul;
the testimony of Yahweh is sure, making wise the simple;
8 the precepts of Yahweh are right, rejoicing the heart;
the commandment of Yahweh is pure, enlightening the eyes;
9 The fear of Yahweh is pure and lasts forever;
the decisions of Yahweh are true and completely right.
10 They are worth more than gold,
even a great deal of pure gold;

they are sweeter than honey,
than honey dripping from the comb.
11 Also by them your servant is made wary;
in the keeping of them there is great reward.
12 Who can discern his own errors?
Clear me from hidden faults.
13 Hold back your servant also from willful sins;
do not let them gain mastery over me!
Then I will be whole
and clean of grave transgression.
14 Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart
be acceptable in your sight,
Yahweh, my rock and my redeemer.

Notes

- a (19:1) Hebrew raqia‘, the vault or dome of the sky (Genesis 1:6–8).
- b (19:4) Or “their sound.” The Septuagint has “their sound,” the form quoted in Romans 10:18.

Chapter 20

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 May Yahweh answer you in the day of trouble!
May the name of the God of Jacob set you on high!
2 May he send you aid out of the holy place
and uphold you out of Zion!
3 May he call to mind all your gifts of grain
and accept as rich your burnt offering!
Selah
4 May he grant you your heart’s desire
and fulfill all your plans!
5 We will sing for joy when you win,
and raise our flags in the name of our God.
May Yahweh grant everything you ask!
6 Now I know that Yahweh saves his anointed;
he will answer him from his holy heaven
with the saving might of his right hand.

7 Some trust in chariots and some in horses,
but we will call upon the name of Yahweh our God.
8 They have buckled and fallen,
but we have stood up and hold our ground.
9 Yahweh, save the king![a]
May he answer us in the day we call.

Notes

- a (20:9) Or, following the Septuagint, "Yahweh, save the king, and answer us in the day we call."

Chapter 21

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 The king shall be glad in your strength, Yahweh,
and how exceedingly he shall rejoice in your salvation![a]
2 The longing of his heart you have given him,
and the request of his lips you have not withheld.
Selah
3 You meet him with rich blessings
and place a crown of pure gold on his head.
4 Life he asked of you; you gave it to him,
length of days forever and ever.
5 Great is his glory through your salvation;
splendor and majesty you lay upon him.
6 For you make him a blessing forever;
you make him glad with joy in your presence.
7 For the king trusts in Yahweh,
and through the covenant love of the Most High he shall not be shaken.
8 Your hand will find out all your enemies;
your right hand will find out those who hate you.
9 You will make them like a blazing oven
when you appear.[b]
Yahweh will swallow them up in his wrath,
and fire will consume them.

10 You will wipe their descendants off the earth
and their children from among humanity.
11 Though they plan evil against you,
though they devise a scheme, they will not succeed.
12 For you will make them turn their backs;
you will aim at their faces with your bowstrings.
13 Be exalted, Yahweh, in your strength!
We will sing and make music to your might.

Notes

- a (21:1) So the qere; the ketiv has a different form of the same verb.
- b (21:9) Hebrew "at the time of your face."

Chapter 22

For the choir leader: on "The Doe of the Dawn." A psalm of David.

1 My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?[b]
Why do you stay so far from helping me,
far from my cries of pain?[c]
2 O my God, I cry in the daytime, and you do not hear,
and in the night season, and I am not silent.
3 But you are holy,
you who inhabit the praises of Israel.
4 Our fathers trusted in you;
they trusted, and you set them free.
5 To you they cried and were set free;
in you they trusted and were not put to shame.
6 But I am a worm, and no man,
a reproach of men and despised of the people.
7 All who see me mock me;
they curl their lips; they wag their heads:
8 "He trusted himself to Yahweh;[d] let him deliver him;
let him rescue him, seeing he delights in him!"
9 Yet you are the one who drew me from the womb;
you made me trust at my mother's breasts.
10 On you I was cast from birth;[e]
from my mother's womb you have been my God.

11 Be not far from me, for trouble is close at hand,
for there is none to help.
12 Many bulls encircle me;
strong bulls of Bashan[f] surround me.
13 They open wide their mouths at me,
a lion tearing and roaring.
14 I am poured out like water,
and all my bones are out of joint;
my heart is like wax;
it has melted within my breast.[g]
15 My strength is dried up like a potsherd,
and my tongue clings to my jaws,
and you have brought me into the dust of death.
16 Dogs surround me;
a pack of wicked men has encircled me;
they have pierced my hands and feet.[h]
17 I may tell all my bones;
they look and stare upon me.
18 they divide my garments among them,
and for my clothing they cast lots.[i]
19 But you, Yahweh, do not be far off!
O my strength, come quickly to my help!
20 Deliver my soul from the sword,
my only life[j] from the power of the dog!
21 Save me from the lion's mouth!
Even from the horns of the wild oxen you have answered me.[k]
22 I will declare your name to my brothers;
in the midst of the assembly I will praise you:[l]
23 Those who fear Yahweh, praise him!
Jacob's whole family, give him glory;
be in awe of him, every child of Israel!
24 For he has not despised nor abhorred
the affliction of the afflicted one;

he has not hidden his face from him,
but when he cried to him, he heard.
25 My praise shall be of you in the great congregation;
I will pay my vows before those who fear him.
26 The humble shall eat and be satisfied;
those who seek Yahweh shall praise him.
May your hearts live forever!
27 All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to Yahweh,
and all the families of the nations shall bow down before you.[m]
28 For kingship belongs to Yahweh,
and he rules over the nations.
29 All the rich of the earth will eat and bow down;
before him will kneel everyone headed for the dust,
even the one unable to preserve his own life.[n]
30 Offspring shall serve him;
it shall be told of the Lord to the generation to come.[o]
31 They will come and declare his righteousness
to a people not yet born,
saying that he has done this.

Notes

- a (22 title) Hebrew ’ayyelet hashshakhar, probably the name of a tune.
- b (22:1) Jesus cried these words from the cross, in Aramaic (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34).
- c (22:1) Hebrew “my roaring.”
- d (22:8) Hebrew “Roll it on Yahweh,” that is, commit your cause to him. Compare Matthew 27:43.
- e (22:10) Hebrew “from the womb.”
- f (22:12) Bashan, the fertile highlands east of the Sea of Galilee, was famous for its cattle (Amos 4:1).
- g (22:14) Hebrew “within my inward parts.”
- h (22:16) So some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint (“they dug”), the Syriac, and Jerome (“they bound” or “they pierced”). A Dead Sea Scroll fragment of this psalm from Nahal Hever (5/6HevPs) reads a verb (ka’aru) that may mean “they dug” or “they pierced.” The Masoretic Text reads ka’ari, “like a lion,” which would give “like a lion, my hands and my feet,” a line that lacks a verb and is hard to construe. The difference in the Hebrew is a single letter (waw or yod), which look alike in many scripts. The New Testament gospels do not quote this line, but they describe the crucifixion in words drawn from this psalm (verses 1, 7–8, 18).

- i (22:18) See John 19:24 and Matthew 27:35.
- j (22:20) Hebrew "my only one," that is, my precious life.
- k (22:21) The sudden "you have answered me" marks the turn from lament to praise. The Septuagint has "and my lowliness from the horns of unicorns."
- l (22:22) Quoted in Hebrews 2:12.
- m (22:27) So the Hebrew; some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac have "before him."
- n (22:29) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult; "the prosperous" is literally "the fat ones."
- o (22:30) Or "to the next generation." The Hebrew may also be read, with the Septuagint, "and my offspring shall serve him."

Chapter 23

A psalm of David.

1 Yahweh is my shepherd;
I shall not be in want.
2 In grassy pastures he makes me lie down;
beside quiet waters he leads me.[a]
3 He renews my life.
He leads me along straight paths[b]
because of his name.
4 Yes, though I walk through the valley of deep darkness,[c]
I will fear no evil, for you are beside me;
your rod and your staff are a comfort to me.
5 You spread a table before me
in the presence of my adversaries;
you anoint my head with oil;
my cup overflows.
6 Surely goodness and covenant love shall pursue me
all the days of my life,
and I shall dwell[d] in the house of Yahweh
for length of days.

Notes

- a (23:2) Hebrew "waters of rest."
- b (23:3) Or "in paths of righteousness."

- c (23:4) Or “the valley of the shadow of death.” The Hebrew tsalmawet was understood by ancient translators as “shadow of death”; many scholars read it as “deep darkness.”
- d (23:6) So the Septuagint; the Hebrew vowels read “I shall return to.”

Chapter 24

Of David. A psalm.

1 The earth is Yahweh’s, and all that fills it,
the world and those who dwell in it,
2 for he has founded it upon the seas
and set it firm upon the rivers.
3 Who shall go up the mountain of Yahweh?
And who shall stand in his holy place?
4 The one with clean hands and a pure heart,
who has not lifted up his soul[a] to what is false
and has not sworn deceitfully.
5 He will receive blessing from Yahweh
and righteousness from the God of his salvation.
6 Such is the generation of those who seek him,[b]
who seek your face, O God of Jacob.[c]
Selah
7 Lift up your heads, you gates!
Rise up, you ancient doors,
so the King of glory may enter.
8 Who is this King of glory?
Yahweh, strong and mighty,
Yahweh, mighty in battle!
9 Lift up your heads, O you gates;
lift them up, you everlasting doors,
and the King of glory shall come in.
10 Who is he, this King of glory?
Yahweh of Armies[d]—
he is the King of glory!
Selah

Notes

- a (24:4) So the qere and many manuscripts; the ketiv has “my soul,” that is, “has not taken my name in vain” (compare Exodus 20:7).
- b (24:6) So the qere; the ketiv is singular.
- c (24:6) So the Septuagint and Syriac; the Hebrew lacks “God of.”
- d (24:10) Hebrew YHWH tseba’ot, often rendered “the LORD of hosts.” The “armies” are the hosts of heaven, the angels and stars, and also the armies of Israel.

Chapter 25

Of David.

1 To you, Yahweh, I lift up my soul.
2 My God, I put my trust in you;
  let me not be put to shame;
  let my enemies not triumph over me.
3 No one who waits for you will be put to shame;
  those who betray without reason will be shamed.
4 Make me know your ways, Yahweh;
  teach me your paths.
5 Guide me in your truth and teach me,
  for you are my saving God;
  I wait for you all day.
6 Remember your mercy, Yahweh, and your covenant love,
  for they have been from of old.
7 Do not remember the sins of my youth, nor my transgressions;
  remember me according to your covenant love,
  for your goodness’ sake, Yahweh.
8 Yahweh is good and just;
  so he teaches sinners the right way.
9 The meek he will guide in judgment,
  and the meek he will teach his way.
10 All the paths of Yahweh are covenant love and faithfulness
  for those who keep his covenant and his testimonies.
11 For your name’s sake, Yahweh,
  pardon my iniquity, for it is great.
12 Who is the man who fears Yahweh?
  Him will he instruct in the way that he should choose.

13 His soul shall abide in prosperity,
and his offspring shall inherit the land.
14 The friendship[b] of Yahweh belongs to those who fear him,
and to them he reveals his covenant.
15 My eyes are ever toward Yahweh,
for he will bring my feet out of the net.
16 Turn yourself to me and have mercy on me,
for I am desolate and afflicted.
17 The troubles of my heart have grown wide;[c]
bring me out of my distresses.
18 Look upon my affliction and my pain,
and forgive all my sins.
19 See how many are my enemies,
and with what violent hatred they hate me.
20 Guard my soul and deliver me;
let me not be put to shame, for I take refuge in you.
21 May integrity and uprightness preserve me,
for I wait for you.
22 Redeem Israel, O God,
out of all his troubles.

Notes

- a (25 title) This psalm is an acrostic: each verse begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, with small irregularities (the letter waw lacks a verse, and qof is replaced). Verse 22 stands outside the pattern.
- b (25:14) Or "the secret counsel," "the intimate circle."
- c (25:17) Or, with a different division of the Hebrew words, "Relieve the troubles of my heart."

Chapter 26

Of David.

1 Clear my name, Yahweh, for I have lived with integrity,
and I have trusted Yahweh without wavering.
2 Examine me, Yahweh, and try me;
test my heart and my mind.[a]
3 For your covenant love is before my eyes,
and I have walked in your truth.

4 I have not sat with deceitful men,
nor will I go in with pretenders.
5 I hate the assembly of evildoers,
and with the wicked I will not sit.
6 I will wash my hands in innocence,
and so will I go about your altar, Yahweh,
7 that I may make the voice of thanksgiving heard
and tell of all your wondrous works.
8 Yahweh, I have loved the dwelling of your house
and the place where your glory resides.
9 Do not gather my soul with sinners,
nor my life with bloodthirsty men,
10 in whose hands is wickedness,
and their right hand is full of bribes.
11 But as for me, I will walk in my integrity;
redeem me and have mercy on me.
12 My foot stands in an even place;
in the congregations I will bless Yahweh.

Notes

- a (26:2) Hebrew "my kidneys and my heart." "Test" follows the qere; the ketiv has a different form of the verb.

Chapter 27

Of David.

1 Yahweh is my light and my salvation;
whom shall I fear?
Yahweh is the stronghold of my life;
of whom shall I be afraid?
2 When evildoers draw near to me to devour my flesh,
my adversaries and my enemies,
it is they who stumble and fall.
3 Though an army encamp against me,
my heart shall not fear;
though war rise up against me,
even then I will be confident.

4 One thing I have asked of Yahweh,
that will I seek:
that I may dwell in the house of Yahweh
all the days of my life,
to behold the beauty of Yahweh
and to inquire[a] in his temple.
5 For in the day of trouble he shall hide me in his pavilion;
in the secret of his tent he shall hide me;
he shall set me up upon a rock.
6 Now my head will be raised above the enemies around me,
and I will offer joyful sacrifices in his tent;
I will sing and make music to Yahweh.
7 Hear, Yahweh, when I cry with my voice;
have mercy also on me and answer me.
8 My heart says of you, "Seek my face."[b]
Your face, Yahweh, is what I seek.
9 Hide not your face far from me;
put not your servant away in anger;
you have been my help;
leave me not, neither forsake me,
O God of my salvation.
10 For my father and my mother have forsaken me,
but Yahweh will take me in.
11 Teach me your way, Yahweh,
and lead me on a level path
because of those who lie in wait for me.
12 Do not hand me over to what my enemies want,
for false witnesses have stood up against me
and are breathing out violence.
13 I believe that I shall see the goodness of Yahweh
in the land of the living![c]
14 Wait for Yahweh;
be strong, and let your heart take courage;
wait for Yahweh!

Notes

- a (27:4) Or "to meditate," "to seek guidance."
- b (27:8) Hebrew "To you my heart said, 'Seek my face.'" The sense is uncertain.
- c (27:13) The Hebrew begins with a word, "unless," marked by the Masoretes as doubtful; read with it, "If I had not believed that I would see…" The word is lacking in the Septuagint.

Chapter 28

Of David.

1 To you, Yahweh, I cry out.
My rock, do not ignore me;
if you say nothing to me,
I will become like those who descend to the pit.
2 Hear the voice of my supplications
when I cry to you,
when I lift up my hands
toward your holy inner sanctuary.[a]
3 Do not pull me away along with the wicked,
the workers of evil,
who talk of peace with their neighbors
but carry malice in their hearts.
4 Repay them for what they have done
and for their evil deeds;
repay them for the work of their hands;
give them what they deserve.
5 Because they do not regard the works of Yahweh
or the work of his hands,
he will tear them down and not build them up.
6 Praise be to Yahweh,
for he has listened to my cry for mercy.
7 Yahweh is my strength and my shield;
I trusted him with my heart, and he helped me;
so my heart is full of joy,
and I will thank him with my song.
8 Yahweh is strength to his people,[b]
and he is the saving strength of his anointed.

9 Save your people, and bless your inheritance;
shepherd them also, and lift them up forever.

Notes

- a (28:2) Hebrew debir, the innermost room of the temple, the Most Holy Place.
- b (28:8) So some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac; most Hebrew manuscripts have "their strength."

Chapter 29

A psalm of David.

1 Ascribe to Yahweh, you sons of God,[a]
ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength.
2 Ascribe to Yahweh the glory due his name;
worship Yahweh in the splendor of holiness.[b]
3 The voice of Yahweh is over the waters;
the God of glory thunders,
Yahweh, over many waters.
4 The voice of Yahweh is powerful;
the voice of Yahweh is full of majesty.
5 The voice of Yahweh breaks the cedars;
Yahweh breaks the cedars of Lebanon.
6 He makes them also to skip like a calf,
Lebanon and Sirion[c] like a young wild ox.
7 The voice of Yahweh splits flames of fire.
8 The voice of Yahweh shakes the wilderness;
Yahweh shakes the wilderness of Kadesh.
9 The voice of Yahweh makes the hinds to calve[d]
and strips the forests bare,
and in his temple everyone says, "Glory!"
10 Yahweh sat enthroned over the flood;[e]
Yahweh sits enthroned as King forever.
11 May Yahweh give strength to his people!
May Yahweh bless his people with peace!

Notes

- a (29:1) Hebrew bene 'elim, "sons of gods," the heavenly beings around God's throne.

- b (29:2) Or “in holy attire.”
- c (29:6) Sirion is the Sidonian name for Mount Hermon (Deuteronomy 3:9).
- d (29:9) Or, with a slight change, “twists the oaks.”
- e (29:10) Hebrew mabbul, used elsewhere only of Noah’s flood (Genesis 6–11).

Chapter 30

A psalm. A song at the dedication of the house. Of David.

1 I will lift you up, Yahweh, for you raised me from the depths,
and you refused to let my enemies rejoice over me.
2 Yahweh my God, I cried to you,
and you have healed me.
3 Yahweh, you have brought up my soul from Sheol;
you have kept me alive, so that I did not go down to the pit.[b]
4 Sing praises to Yahweh, you his faithful ones,
and give thanks to his holy name.[c]
5 His anger lasts only a moment,
but his kindness lasts a lifetime.
Crying may stay for the night,
but joy arrives in the morning.
6 As for me, I said in my prosperity,
“I shall never be moved.”
7 Yahweh, by your favor you made my mountain stand strong;
you hid your face; I was dismayed.
8 To you, Yahweh, I cried,
and to the Lord I pleaded for mercy:
9 “What gain is there in my blood
when I go down to the pit?
Shall the dust praise you?
Shall it declare your truth?
10 Hear, Yahweh, and be gracious to me!
Yahweh, be my helper!”
11 You have turned my mourning into dancing for me;
you have loosed my sackcloth and clothed me with gladness,
12 so that my glory[d] may sing praise to you and not be silent.
Yahweh my God, I will give thanks to you forever!

Notes

- a (30 title) Perhaps the temple, or David's palace; Jewish tradition has used this psalm at Hanukkah, the feast of the rededication of the temple.
- b (30:3) So the qere; the ketiv has "from among those who go down to the pit."
- c (30:4) Hebrew "to the remembrance of his holiness."
- d (30:12) That is, my soul, or my whole being.

Chapter 31

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 In you, Yahweh, I have taken refuge;
let me never be ashamed;
deliver me in your righteousness.
2 Bow down your ear to me;
rescue me speedily!
Be my strong rock,
a fortress to save me.
3 For you are my crag and my fortress;
therefore for your name's sake lead me and guide me.
4 Pull me out of the net that they have hidden for me,
for you are my stronghold.
5 Into your hand I commit my spirit;[a]
you have redeemed me, Yahweh, God of truth.
6 I hate those who cling to worthless idols,[b]
but I trust in Yahweh.
7 I will be glad and rejoice in your covenant love,
for you have seen my affliction;
you have known the distresses of my soul,
8 and you have not shut me up in the hand of the enemy;
you have set my feet in a broad place.
9 Have pity on me, Yahweh, for I am in distress;
my eyes are worn out from sorrow,
and so are my soul and body.
10 For my life is spent with sorrow,
and my years with sighing;
my strength fails because of my iniquity,[c]
and my bones waste away.

11 Because of all my foes I have become a reproach,
above all to my neighbors,
and a fear to those who know me;
those who see me outside run from me.
12 I am forgotten like a dead man, out of mind;
I have become like a broken vessel.
13 For I have heard the whispering of many—
terror on every side!—
while they plot together against me,
they scheme to take away my life.
14 But I trusted in you, Yahweh;
I said, "You are my God."
15 My times are in your hand;
deliver me from the hand of my enemies and from those who persecute me!
16 Let your face shine on your servant;
save me for your covenant love's sake.
17 Yahweh, let me not be ashamed, for I call upon you;
let the wicked be ashamed;
let them be silent in Sheol.
18 Let the lying lips be struck dumb,
which speak arrogantly against the righteous
in pride and contempt.
19 How abundant is the good
that you keep in store for those who fear you,
that you carry out in front of all people
for those who find refuge in you!
20 You hide them in the secret of your presence
from the schemes of men;
you keep them secretly in a booth
from the strife of tongues.
21 Blessed be Yahweh,
for he has shown me his marvelous covenant love
in a besieged city.

22 As for me, I said in my alarm,
"I am cut off from before your eyes."
Nevertheless you heard the voice of my supplications
when I cried to you.
23 Love Yahweh, all you his faithful ones!
Yahweh preserves the faithful
and repays in full the one who acts proudly.
24 Be strong, and let your heart take courage,
all you who hope in Yahweh!

Notes

- a (31:5) Jesus spoke these words as he died (Luke 23:46).
- b (31:6) Hebrew "vanities of emptiness." So the Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts; the Masoretic Text has "I hate."
- c (31:10) The Septuagint and Syriac have "because of my affliction."

Chapter 32

Of David. A Maskil.

1 Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven,
whose sin is covered.[b]
2 Blessed is the man to whom Yahweh does not count iniquity,
and in whose spirit there is no deceit.
3 When I kept silent, my bones wasted away
through my groaning all day long.
4 For day and night your hand was heavy upon me;
my moisture was turned into the drought of summer.[c]
Selah
5 I admitted my sin to you
and did not cover up my guilt;
I said, "I will confess my rebellion to Yahweh,"
and you forgave the guilt of my sin.
Selah
6 Therefore let everyone who is faithful pray to you
at a time when you may be found;[d]
surely in the flood of great waters
they shall not reach him.

7 You are my shelter;
you protect me from trouble;
you surround me with songs of rescue.
Selah
8 I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go;
I will counsel you with my eye upon you.
9 Do not be like the horse or like the mule, without understanding,
whose trappings must be bit and bridle to hold them in,
or they will not come near you.
10 Many are the sorrows of the wicked,
but covenant love surrounds the one who trusts in Yahweh.
11 Be glad in Yahweh and celebrate, you righteous,
and sing for joy, all you who are honest in heart!

Notes

- a (32 title) Hebrew maskil, a term of uncertain meaning found in thirteen psalm titles; perhaps "a skillful psalm" or "an instructive psalm" (compare verse 8, "I will instruct you," from the same root).
- b (32:1) Verses 1–2 are quoted in Romans 4:7–8.
- c (32:4) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (32:6) Hebrew "at a time of finding." The sense is uncertain.

Chapter 33

1 Shout for joy in Yahweh, O you righteous!
Praise is fitting for the upright.
2 Give thanks to Yahweh with the lyre;
make music to him with the ten-stringed harp!
3 Sing to him a new song;
play skillfully with a loud shout.
4 For the word of Yahweh is upright,
and all his work is done in faithfulness.
5 He loves righteousness and justice;
the earth is full of the covenant love of Yahweh.
6 By the word of Yahweh the heavens came to be,
and all their array by the breath of his mouth.
7 He piles up the sea's waters like a mound;[a]
he stores the oceans in vaults.

8 Let all the earth fear Yahweh;
  let all the inhabitants of the world stand in awe of him.
9 For he spoke, and it was;
  he commanded, and it stood firm.
10 Yahweh brings the counsel of the nations to nothing;
  he frustrates the devices of the peoples.
11 The plans of Yahweh last forever,
  the purposes of his heart through every generation.
12 Blessed is the nation whose God is Yahweh,
  the people he has chosen as his heritage!
13 Yahweh looks down from heaven;
  he beholds all the children of man;
14 from the place of his dwelling he gazes
  on all the inhabitants of the earth,
15 he who fashions the hearts of them all
  and discerns all their deeds.
16 No king is saved by the size of his army;
  a mighty man is not delivered by great strength.
17 A horse is a false hope for safety;
  for all its great strength it will not deliver.
18 Behold, the eye of Yahweh is on those who fear him,
  on those who hope in his covenant love,
19 to deliver their soul from death
  and to keep them alive in famine.
20 Our soul waits for Yahweh;
  he is our help and our shield.
21 For our heart shall rejoice in him,
  because we have trusted in his holy name.
22 Let your covenant love, Yahweh, rest upon us,
  just as we have hoped in you.

Notes

- a (33:7) Or, with the ancient versions, “as in a skin bottle.”

Chapter 34

Of David, when he disguised his sanity before Abimelech, who drove him away, and he departed.

1 I will bless Yahweh at all times;
his praise shall continually be in my mouth.
2 My soul shall make its boast in Yahweh;
let the humble hear and be glad.
3 Oh, magnify Yahweh with me,
and let us exalt his name together!
4 I sought Yahweh, and he answered me
and delivered me from all my terrors.
5 Those who looked to him were radiant,[b]
and their faces were never ashamed.
6 This poor man cried, and Yahweh heard him
and saved him out of all his troubles.
7 The angel of Yahweh encamps around those who fear him,
and he rescues them.
8 Taste and see that Yahweh is good![c]
Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!
9 Fear Yahweh, you his saints,
for there is no want to those who fear him.
10 The young lions suffer want and hunger,
but those who seek Yahweh shall not lack any good thing.
11 Come, you children, listen to me;
I will teach you the fear of Yahweh.
12 Who is the man who desires life
and loves many days, that he may see good?[d]
13 Keep your tongue from evil
and your lips from speaking deceit.
14 Turn away from evil and do good;
seek peace and pursue it.
15 The eyes of Yahweh are toward the righteous,
and his ears are open to their cry.

16 The face of Yahweh is against those who do evil,
to cut off the memory of them from the earth.
17 The righteous cry,[e] and Yahweh hears
and delivers them out of all their troubles.
18 Yahweh is close to those of a broken heart
and saves such as are of a crushed spirit.
19 Many are the afflictions of the righteous,
but Yahweh delivers him out of them all.
20 He keeps all his bones;
not one of them is broken.[f]
21 Evil shall slay the wicked,
and those who hate the righteous shall be held guilty.
22 Yahweh redeems the soul of his servants;
none of those who take refuge in him shall be held guilty.

Notes

- a (34 title) This psalm is an acrostic, each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet; the letter waw is lacking, and verse 22 stands outside the pattern (as in Psalm 25). The title recalls 1 Samuel 21:10–15, where the king of Gath is named Achish; Abimelech may have been a royal title among the Philistines (compare Genesis 20; 26).
- b (34:5) So the Hebrew; some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac have "Look to him and be radiant, and your faces shall not be ashamed."
- c (34:8) Compare 1 Peter 2:3.
- d (34:12) Verses 12–16 are quoted in 1 Peter 3:10–12.
- e (34:17) Hebrew "They cry."
- f (34:20) Compare John 19:36.

Chapter 35

Of David.

1 Contend, Yahweh, with those who contend with me;
fight against those who fight against me!
2 Take hold of shield and buckler
and rise up for my help!
3 Draw out the spear and the battle-ax[a] against my pursuers!
Say to my soul, "I am your salvation!"
4 Let those who seek my life
be confounded and put to shame!

Let those who plot my harm
be turned back and brought to confusion!
5 May they be as chaff before the wind,
the angel of Yahweh thrusting them on!
6 Let their way be dark and slippery,
with the angel of Yahweh pursuing them!
7 For they hid their net for me in a pit without cause;
without cause they dug for my soul.
8 Let ruin come upon him when he does not know it;
let his own net that he has hidden catch him;
into that very ruin let him fall!
9 Then my soul will rejoice in Yahweh,
exulting in his salvation.
10 All my bones will say,
"Yahweh, who is like you?
You deliver the poor from someone stronger than they are,
the poor and needy from the one who plunders them."
11 Malicious witnesses rise up;
they ask me of things that I do not know.
12 They paid me back evil for good,
leaving my soul forlorn.[b]
13 But as for me, when they were sick, my clothing was sackcloth;
I humbled my soul with fasting;
and my prayer returned into my own bosom.[c]
14 I walked around as if mourning a friend or brother;
I bent low in grief,
like someone weeping for his mother.
15 But in my limping they were glad and came together;
the smiters gathered against me,
and I did not know it;
they tore and did not cease;
16 like godless jesters mocking for a cake,[d]
they ground their teeth at me.

17 Lord, how long will you just watch?
Save my soul from their destruction,
my precious life[e] from these lions!
18 I will give you thanks in the great congregation;
among a mighty people I will praise you.
19 Do not let my enemies gloat over me without cause,
or those who hate me for no reason exchange knowing glances.[f]
20 For they do not speak peace,
but they devise deceitful words
against those who are quiet in the land.
21 Yes, they opened their mouth wide against me
and said, "Aha, aha, our eye has seen it!"
22 You have seen, Yahweh; do not keep silent!
Lord, be not far from me!
23 Rouse yourself, awake for my justice,
for my cause, my God and my Lord!
24 Declare me right, Yahweh my God, by your righteousness,
and do not let them gloat over me!
25 Let them not say in their heart, "Aha, so would we have it!"
Let them not say, "We have devoured him."
26 Let them be ashamed and confounded together
who rejoice at my calamity!
Let them be clothed with shame and dishonor
who magnify themselves against me!
27 May those who want to see me vindicated
sing for joy and be glad;
may they always say,
"Yahweh is great; he takes pleasure in his servant's well-being!"
28 Then my tongue will utter your righteousness,
your praise, the whole day through.

Notes

- a (35:3) Or "and close the way."
- b (35:12) Hebrew "bereavement to my soul."
- c (35:13) Perhaps meaning that he prayed with his head bowed upon his chest, or that his prayer was in vain.

- d (35:16) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (35:17) Hebrew "my only one," as in Psalm 22:20.
- f (35:19) Compare John 15:25, "They hated me without a cause."

Chapter 36

For the choir leader. Of David, the servant of Yahweh.

1 Transgression speaks to the wicked
deep within his heart;[a]
there is no fear of God before his eyes.[b]
2 For he flatters himself in his own eyes
that his iniquity will not be found out and hated.
3 The words of his mouth are wickedness and deceit;
he has ceased to act wisely and to do good.
4 He devises mischief on his bed;
he sets himself on a way that is not good;
he does not reject evil.
5 Your covenant love, Yahweh, reaches to the heavens,
your faithfulness to the clouds.
6 Your righteousness is like the mountains of God;
your judgments are a great deep;
man and beast you preserve, Yahweh.
7 How precious is your covenant love, O God!
The children of man take refuge in the shadow of your wings.
8 They shall be filled to the full with the fatness of your house,
and you will make them drink of the river of your delights.[c]
9 For with you is the fountain of life;
in your light we see light.
10 Continue your covenant love to those who know you,
and your righteousness to the upright in heart!
11 Let not the foot of the proud come upon me,
nor the hand of the wicked drive me away.
12 There the workers of iniquity have fallen;
they are thrust down and cannot rise.

Notes

- a (36:1) So some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac; most Hebrew manuscripts have “my heart.” Hebrew “An oracle of transgression to the wicked.”
- b (36:1) Quoted in Romans 3:18.
- c (36:8) Hebrew ʿadanekha, from the same root as “Eden.”

Chapter 37

Of David.

1 Do not fret yourself because of evildoers,
nor be envious of those who work unrighteousness!
2 For like the grass they will soon wither
and fade like the green herb.
3 Trust in Yahweh and do good;
dwell in the land and feed on faithfulness.[b]
4 Take delight in Yahweh,
and he will give you the requests of your heart.
5 Roll your way onto Yahweh;
trust in him, and he will act.
6 He will make your righteousness go forth as the light,
and your just cause as the noon.
7 Be quiet before Yahweh and wait for him patiently;
do not be upset by people who succeed in their ways,
by those who carry out evil plans!
8 Leave off from anger and let go of wrath!
Do not fret yourself; it tends only to evil.
9 For evildoers shall be cut off,
but those who wait for Yahweh shall inherit the land.
10 For yet a little while, and the wicked shall not be;
yes, you shall diligently consider his place, and it shall not be.
11 But the meek shall inherit the land[c]
and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace.
12 The wicked schemes against the just
and gnashes on him with his teeth.
13 but the Lord laughs at him,
for he sees that his day is coming.

14 The wicked have drawn the sword and bent their bow
to bring down the poor and needy,
to slay those whose way is upright;
15 their sword shall enter their own heart,
and their bows shall be broken.
16 Better is the little that the righteous has
than the abundance of many wicked.
17 For the arms of the wicked shall be broken,
but Yahweh upholds the righteous.
18 Yahweh knows the days of the upright,
and their inheritance shall be forever.
19 they will not be put to shame in the evil time;
in the days of famine they will have plenty.
20 But the wicked shall perish;
and the enemies of Yahweh shall be as the glory of the pastures;[d]
they shall be consumed; into smoke they shall be consumed away.
21 The wicked borrows and pays not back again,
but the righteous shows mercy and gives.
22 for those blessed by him[e] shall inherit the land,
but those cursed by him shall be cut off.
23 The steps of a man are established by Yahweh
when he delights in his way;
24 though he falls, he shall not be cast headlong,
for Yahweh holds his hand.
25 I was young and now I am old,
yet I have never seen the righteous abandoned
or their children begging for bread.
26 All the day long he is gracious and lends,
and his children become a blessing.
27 Depart from evil and do good,
and dwell forevermore.
28 For Yahweh loves justice;
he will not forsake his faithful ones.

They are preserved forever,[f]
but the children of the wicked shall be cut off.
29 The righteous shall inherit the land
and dwell upon it forever.
30 The righteous man's mouth murmurs wisdom,
and his tongue speaks what is just.
31 The law of his God is in his heart;
his steps do not slip.
32 The wicked keeps watch on the righteous
and seeks to kill him.
33 Yahweh will not leave him in his hand,
nor condemn him when he is judged.
34 Wait for Yahweh and keep his way,
and he will exalt you to inherit the land;
you will see it when the wicked are cut off.
35 I have seen the wicked in great power,
spreading himself like a green tree in its native soil.[g]
36 Yet he passed away,[h] and lo, he was not;
yes, I sought him, but he could not be found.
37 Mark the blameless and behold the upright,
for there is a future[i] for the man of peace.
38 But transgressors shall be destroyed together;
the future of the wicked shall be cut off.
39 The salvation of the righteous is from Yahweh;
he is their stronghold in the time of trouble.
40 And Yahweh shall help them and deliver them;
he shall deliver them from the wicked and save them,
because they trust in him.

Notes

- a (37 title) This psalm is an acrostic: every second verse, roughly, begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, so that each letter introduces a stanza of about two verses.
- b (37:3) Or "and befriend faithfulness," or "and you shall feed securely."
- c (37:11) Compare Matthew 5:5.
- d (37:20) Or "like the burning of furnaces." The Hebrew is uncertain.

- e (37:22) That is, by Yahweh.
- f (37:28) The ayin stanza appears here; the Septuagint has “The lawless shall be driven out,” which some take to preserve the letter.
- g (37:35) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has “like the cedars of Lebanon.”
- h (37:36) So the Septuagint, Syriac, and Vulgate; the Hebrew has “he passed away” in some manuscripts and “one passed by” in others.
- i (37:37) Or “posterity.”

Chapter 38

A psalm of David, for the memorial offering.

1 Yahweh, do not punish me in your anger
or discipline me in your fury.
2 For your arrows stick fast in me,
and your hand presses me down.
3 There is no soundness in my flesh because of your indignation;
there is no health in my bones because of my sin.
4 My guilt has risen over my head;
it weighs on me like a load too heavy to carry.
5 My wounds reek and are rotten
because of my foolishness.
6 I am bent and bowed down greatly;
all the day I go about mourning.
7 For my loins are filled with burning,
and there is no soundness in my flesh.
8 I am feeble and utterly crushed;
I groan because of the turmoil of my heart.
9 Lord, all my desire is before you,
and my groaning is not hidden from you.
10 My heart pounds; my strength is gone;
even the light of my eyes has left me.
11 My loved ones and my friends stand aloof from my plague,
and my kinsmen stand far off.
12 Those who seek my life lay snares;
those who seek my hurt speak of ruin
and meditate on treachery all day long.

13 But I am like the deaf; I hear nothing,
like the dumb, who opens not his mouth.
14 Thus I am as a man who hears not,
in whose mouth are no reproofs.
15 But for you, Yahweh, I wait;
it is you who will answer, Lord my God.
16 For I said, “Let them not rejoice over me,
who magnify themselves against me when my foot slips!”
17 For I am ready to stumble,
and my pain is ever before me.
18 For I will declare my iniquity;
I am troubled over my sin.
19 But my enemies are vigorous; they are strong,[b]
and many are those who hate me wrongfully.
20 They also who render evil for good are my adversaries,
because I follow what is good.[c]
21 Do not forsake me, Yahweh!
My God, be not far from me!
22 Make haste to help me,
Lord, my salvation!

Notes

- a (38 title) Hebrew lehazkir, “to bring to remembrance.” The same word appears in the title of Psalm 70; it may refer to the memorial portion of the grain offering (Leviticus 2:2).
- b (38:19) Hebrew “my enemies are living.” A Dead Sea Scroll (4QPs-a) reads “without cause,” matching the parallel line.
- c (38:20) So the qere; the ketiv has a different form of the same word.

Chapter 39

For the choir leader: for Jeduthun. A psalm of David.

1 I said, “I will take heed to my ways,
that I do not sin with my tongue;
I will keep a bridle on my mouth
while the wicked is before me.”

2 I was mute with silence;
I held my peace, to no avail,[b]
and my sorrow was stirred up.
3 My heart was hot inside me;
in my musing a fire was kindled;
then I spoke out with my tongue:
4 “Yahweh, cause me to know my end,
and the measure of my days, what it is,
that I may know how frail I am.
5 Look, you have made my days only a few inches long,[c]
and my lifespan is nothing in your sight.
Truly every human being, though secure, is only a breath.
Selah
6 Surely every man walks about as a phantom;
surely they are in an uproar for nothing;
he heaps up riches and knows not who shall gather them.
7 “And now, Lord, what do I wait for?
My hope is in you.
8 Rescue me from all my transgressions;
do not set me up as the taunt of the fool.
9 I was dumb; I opened not my mouth,
because you did it.
10 Remove your stroke from me;
I am consumed by the blow of your hand.
11 When with rebukes you correct a man for iniquity,
you make his beauty consume away like a moth;
surely every man is a breath.
Selah
12 “Hear my prayer, Yahweh,
and listen to my cry;
do not stay silent when I weep;
for I am a foreigner living with you,
a stranger like all my ancestors.
13 Turn your gaze from me, that I may brighten,
before I go hence and be no more.”

Notes

- a (39 title) So the qere; the ketiv spells the name Jedithun. Jeduthun was one of David's chief musicians (1 Chronicles 16:41–42; 25:1). The name is also in the titles of Psalms 62 and 77.
- b (39:2) Hebrew "away from good."
- c (39:5) A handbreadth is about 7.5 centimeters (3 inches). Hebrew hebel, "breath, vapor," is the word rendered "vanity" in Ecclesiastes.

Chapter 40

For the choir leader. Of David. A psalm.

1 I waited patiently for Yahweh;
he inclined to me and heard my cry.
2 He brought me up out of a horrible pit,[a]
out of the miry clay,
and set my feet upon a rock
and established my goings.
3 And he has put a new song in my mouth,
praise to our God;
many shall see it and fear
and shall trust in Yahweh.
4 Blessed is the man who makes Yahweh his trust,
and does not regard the proud,
nor such as turn aside to lies.
5 Many, Yahweh my God, are the wonders you have done,
and your thoughts toward us;
none can be set in order beside you;
if I would declare and speak of them,
they are more than can be numbered.
6 Sacrifice and offering you did not desire;
ears you have opened for me;[b]
burnt offering and sin offering
you have not required.
7 Then I said, "Lo, I come;
in the scroll of the book it is written of me:
8 I delight to do your will, O my God;
yes, your law is within my inmost parts."

9 I have preached righteousness in the great congregation;
lo, I have not held back my lips,
Yahweh, you know.
10 I have not kept your righteousness hidden in my heart;
I have told of your faithfulness and rescue;
I have not kept your steadfast love and truth
secret from the great assembly.
11 As for you, Yahweh, you will not withhold your mercy from me;
your covenant love and your truth will ever preserve me!
12 For evils without number have compassed me about;
my iniquities have taken hold of me, so that I cannot look up;
they are more than the hairs of my head,
and my heart forsakes me.
13 Be pleased, Yahweh, to deliver me![c]
Yahweh, make haste to help me!
14 Let them be ashamed and confounded together
who seek after my soul to destroy it;
let them be driven backward and put to shame
who wish me evil.
15 Let them be desolate as a reward for their shame
who say to me, "Aha, aha!"
16 Let all who seek you
rejoice and be glad in you;
let such as love your salvation
say continually, "Yahweh be magnified!"
17 But I am poor and needy;
yet the Lord thinks of me.
You are my help and my deliverer;
make no delay, O my God.

Notes

- a (40:2) Or "the pit of tumult."
- b (40:6) Hebrew "ears you have dug for me." The Septuagint has "but a body you have prepared for me," the reading quoted in Hebrews 10:5–7.
- c (40:13) Verses 13–17 appear again, with small differences, as Psalm 70.

Chapter 41

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 Blessed is he who considers the poor!
Yahweh will deliver him in the time of trouble;
2 Yahweh will preserve him and keep him alive,
and he shall be blessed upon the earth;[a]
and you will not hand him over to the will of his enemies.
3 Yahweh will strengthen him upon the bed of languishing;
you will make all his bed in his sickness.[b]
4 As for me, I said, "Yahweh, be gracious to me;
heal my soul, for I have sinned against you!"
5 My enemies speak evil of me:
"When shall he die and his name perish?"
6 And if one comes to see me, he speaks emptiness;
his heart gathers iniquity to itself;
when he goes outside, he tells it.
7 All who hate me whisper together against me;
against me they devise my hurt.
8 "A thing of ruin,"[c] they say, "clings fast to him;
and now that he lies down he shall rise up no more."
9 Even my close friend, whom I trusted,
the one who shared my bread,
has raised his heel against me.[d]
10 But you, Yahweh, be gracious to me,
and raise me up, that I may repay them!
11 This is how I know you are pleased with me:
my enemy has not won a victory over me.
12 And as for me, you uphold me in my integrity
and set me before your face forever.
13 Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Israel,
from everlasting to everlasting!
Amen and Amen.[e]

Notes

- a (41:2) So the qere; the ketiv has "and may he be called blessed."

- b (41:3) Hebrew "all his bed you turn over in his illness."
- c (41:8) Hebrew "a thing of Belial," that is, of worthlessness or ruin.
- d (41:9) Hebrew "the man of my peace." Quoted by Jesus of Judas in John 13:18.
- e (41:13) This doxology closes Book One of the Psalms (Psalms 1–41). Each of the five books ends with a similar blessing (41:13; 72:18–19; 89:52; 106:48), and Psalm 150 closes the whole.

Chapter 42

Book Two (Psalms 42–72)

For the choir leader. A Maskil of the sons of Korah.

1 As a deer longs for streams of water,
so my soul longs for you, O God.
2 My soul thirsts for God, for the living God.
When shall I come and appear before the face of God?
3 My tears have been my food by day and night,
while people keep asking me all day,
"Where is your God?"
4 These things I call to mind, and I pour out my soul within me:
how I used to go with the crowd
and walk at their head to the house of God
with the voice of joy and praise,
a throng keeping holy day.
5 Why are you bowed down, O my soul,
and why do you moan within me?
Hope in God, for I shall again praise him,
the salvation of his presence.[b]
6 O my God, my soul is bowed down within me;
therefore I remember you from the land of the Jordan
and of the Hermons, from Mount Mizar.[c]
7 Deep calls out to deep
at the thunder of your cataracts;
all your breakers and your billows
have swept over me.
8 By day Yahweh commands his covenant love,
and in the night his song is with me,
a prayer to the God of my life.

9 I say to God, my rock,
"Why have you forgotten me?
Why must I walk in mourning
under the oppression of the enemy?"
10 As with a shattering in my bones,[d] my foes revile me,
saying to me every day,
"Where is your God?"
11 Why are you bowed down, O my soul,
and why do you moan within me?
Hope in God, for I shall again praise him,
the salvation of my face and my God.

Notes

- a (42 title) Book Two of the Psalms (Psalms 42–72). In much of this collection (Psalms 42–83, the so-called Elohistic Psalter) the divine name Yahweh is used far less often and the general word "God" (Elohim) far more often than elsewhere; compare Psalm 14 with Psalm 53, and Psalm 40:13–17 with Psalm 70. The sons of Korah were a guild of Levitical singers and gatekeepers descended from Korah (Numbers 26:11; 1 Chronicles 9:19; 2 Chronicles 20:19). Psalms 42–49, 84–85, and 87–88 bear their name. Many Hebrew manuscripts treat Psalms 42 and 43 as a single psalm; they share a refrain (42:5, 11; 43:5).
- b (42:5) Hebrew "the salvations of his face." Some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Syriac join the first word of verse 6 to this verse and read "the salvation of my face, and my God," as in verse 11 and 43:5.
- c (42:6) Mount Mizar, "the little mountain," is otherwise unknown; the setting is the headwaters of the Jordan below Mount Hermon.
- d (42:10) Or "like a sword in my bones." The Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 43

1 Vindicate me, O God, and plead my cause
against an unfaithful nation;
from the man of deceit and injustice
deliver me!
2 For you are the God of my refuge;
why have you cast me off?
Why do I walk in mourning
under the oppression of the enemy?

3 Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me;
let them bring me to your holy mountain
and to your dwelling places!
4 Then I will go to God's altar,
to God, my greatest joy,
and I will praise you with the harp,
God, my God.
5 Why are you bowed down, O my soul,
and why do you moan within me?
Hope in God, for I shall again praise him,
the salvation of my face and my God.

Chapter 44

For the choir leader. Of the sons of Korah. A Maskil.

1 O God, we have heard with our ears;
our fathers have recounted to us
the work you did in their days,
in the days of old:
2 With your hand you dispossessed the nations
and planted our fathers;
you brought harm on the peoples
and sent our fathers spreading out.[a]
3 For it was not by their sword that they took the land in possession,
and it was not their arm that gave them victory,
but your right hand, your arm,
and the light of your face,
for you favored them.
4 You are my King, O God;
command victories[b] for Jacob!
5 Through you we push back our adversaries;
through your name we trample those who rise up against us.
6 For I will not rely on my bow,
and my sword will not give me victory.
7 But you have saved us from our adversaries
and have put to shame those who hate us.

8 All day long we have boasted in God,
and we will praise your name forever.
Selah
9 Yet you have spurned us and disgraced us
and do not go out with our armies.
10 You make us retreat before the adversary,
and those who hate us plunder at will.
11 You have handed us over like sheep for eating
and have scattered us among the nations.
12 You sell your people for a trifle,
and you gain nothing by their price.
13 You have made us the reproach of our neighbors,
the derision and mockery of those around us.
14 You have made us a byword among the nations,
a shaking of the head among the peoples.
15 My dishonor is before me every day,
and the shame of my face has covered me,
16 because of the voice of the one who reproaches and blasphemes,
because of the enemy who takes revenge.
17 All this has befallen us,
and still we have not forgotten you
or dealt falsely with your covenant.
18 Our heart has not turned back,
nor have our steps strayed from your path,
19 that you should have crushed us in the haunt of jackals[c]
and covered us over with deep darkness.
20 If we had forgotten the name of our God
or spread out our hands to a foreign god,
21 would not God search this out?
For he knows the secrets of the heart.
22 But for your sake we are slain all the day long;
we are reckoned as sheep for slaughter.[d]
23 Wake up! Why do you sleep, Lord?
Rouse yourself! Do not cast us off forever!

24 Why is your face hidden?
Why have you forgotten our misery and our oppression?
25 For our soul is sunk down to the dust;
our belly clings to the ground.
26 Arise and help us!
Redeem us because of your covenant love!

Notes

- a (44:2) Or "but them you set free."
- b (44:4) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Syriac have "You are my King and my God, who commands victories."
- c (44:19) So the Hebrew; some manuscripts read "sea monster."
- d (44:22) Quoted in Romans 8:36.

Chapter 45

For the choir director: set to "Lilies." Of the sons of Korah. A Maskil. A love song.

1 My heart is stirred by a noble word;
I speak what I have composed for the king;
my tongue is the pen of a nimble writer.
2 You are the most handsome of men;
gracious words flow from your lips;
for this God has blessed you forever.
3 Strap your sword upon your thigh, O mighty one,
your splendor and your majesty!
4 In your splendor, ride out in triumph
for the sake of truth, humility and justice;[c]
let your right hand show you fearsome deeds.
5 Your arrows are sharp in the heart of the king's enemies;
peoples fall beneath you.
6 Your throne, O God, endures forever and ever.[d]
A scepter of equity is the scepter of your kingdom.
7 You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness.
Therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of gladness beyond your companions.

8 Myrrh and aloes and cassia scent all your garments;
out of ivory palaces strings make you glad.
9 Princesses are among your honored guests;
the queen stands at your right in gold from Ophir.
10 Listen, daughter; consider and bend your ear:
forget your own people and the house of your father,
11 so shall the king long for your beauty.
He is your lord; bow before him.
12 The daughter of Tyre comes bearing a present;
the wealthy among the people entreat your favor.
13 The princess is entirely splendid inside the palace;[e]
her dress is woven with gold.
14 In robes of many colors she is brought to the king;
the maidens who follow her, her companions,
are brought in to you.
15 With gladness and rejoicing they are led along;
they enter the palace of the king.
16 Your sons shall take the place of your fathers;
you shall make them rulers over all the land.
17 I will cause your name to be remembered in all generations;
therefore peoples will praise you forever and ever.

Notes

- a (45 title) Hebrew shoshannim, probably the name of a tune (also in the titles of Psalms 60, 69, and 80).
- b (45 title) A song for a royal wedding, addressed to the king (verses 2–9) and to his bride (verses 10–15).
- c (45:4) The Hebrew is unusual; perhaps "for truth and humble righteousness."
- d (45:6) So the Hebrew, the Septuagint, and other ancient versions, which address the king as "God" ('elohim). Hebrews 1:8–9 quotes verses 6–7 in this form of the Son. Other proposed renderings are "Your throne is God's, forever and ever," "Your divine throne endures forever," or "Your throne is like God's throne," but the direct address is the most natural reading of the Hebrew.
- e (45:13) Hebrew "within."

Chapter 46

For the choir leader. Of the sons of Korah. According to Alamoth. A song.

1 God is our refuge and strength,
a help in troubles, readily found.
2 Therefore we will not fear though the earth be changed,
though the mountains slip into the heart of the seas,
3 though its waters roar and churn,
though the mountains shake with its surging.
Selah
4 A river's streams make glad the city of God,
the sacred home of the Most High.
5 God is in her midst; she shall not be moved;
God will help her at the turning of the morning.
6 Nations raged; kingdoms tottered;
he gave forth his voice; the earth melted.
7 Yahweh of Armies is with us;
the God of Jacob is our high fortress.
Selah
8 Come, see the works of Yahweh,
how he has brought desolations on the earth.
9 He ends wars all over the earth;
he breaks bows and shatters spears;
he sets the wagons[b] on fire.
10 "Be still, and know that I am God.
I will be exalted among the nations;
I will be exalted in the earth!"
11 Yahweh of Armies is with us;
the God of Jacob is our high fortress.
Selah

Notes

- a (46 title) Hebrew 'alamot, perhaps "young women," that is, for soprano voices (compare 1 Chronicles 15:20).
- b (46:9) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has "shields."

Chapter 47

For the choir leader. Of the sons of Korah. A psalm.

1 Clap your hands, all you peoples!
  Shout to God with a ringing cry!
2 For Yahweh, the Most High, is fearsome,
  a great King over the whole earth.
3 He subdues peoples under us,
  and nations under our feet.
4 He selects our inheritance for us,
  the pride of Jacob, his beloved.
  Selah
5 God has gone up with a shout,
  Yahweh with the blast of a trumpet.[a]
6 Sing praises to God, sing praises!
  Sing praises to our King, sing praises!
7 For God is the King of all the earth;
  sing praises with a skillful psalm![b]
8 God reigns over the nations;
  God sits on his holy throne.
9 The nobles of the peoples are gathered
  as the people of the God of Abraham;
  for the shields[c] of the earth belong to God;
  he is highly exalted.

Notes

- a (47:5) Hebrew shofar, a ram's horn.
- b (47:7) Hebrew maskil; see the note on Psalm 32 title.
- c (47:9) That is, the rulers.

Chapter 48

A song. A psalm of the sons of Korah.

1 Great is Yahweh and greatly to be praised
  in the city of our God, his holy mountain.
2 Majestic in height, the delight of the whole earth,
  is Mount Zion, the remote heights of the north,[a]
  the city of the great King.
3 God, in her strongholds,
  has shown himself a sure defense.

4 For behold, the kings assembled;
they came on together.
5 They saw, and so they were astounded;
they were terrified; they hurried away.
6 Trembling seized them there,
anguish like that of a woman in labor,
7 as when the east wind
shatters the ships of Tarshish.
8 What we heard, we have now seen
in the city of Yahweh of Armies,
in the city of our God;
God will keep it secure forever.
Selah
9 We have pondered your covenant love, O God,
in the midst of your temple.
10 Like your name, O God,
your praise extends to the ends of the earth;
righteousness fills your right hand.
11 Let Mount Zion be glad!
Let the daughters of Judah rejoice
because of your judgments!
12 Walk about Zion; go all around her;
count her towers;
13 mark well her ramparts;
pass through her citadels,
that you may tell it to the generation to come,
14 that this is God,
our God forever and ever.
He will guide us beyond death.[b]

Notes

- a (48:2) Hebrew tsaphon, "north," also the name of the sacred mountain of Canaanite myth (Mount Zaphon); the psalm claims for Zion the honor others gave to Zaphon.

- b (48:14) Hebrew ‘al-mut, “over death” or “to death.” The Septuagint and some Hebrew manuscripts read ‘olamot, “forever.” The phrase may also be a musical direction belonging with the title of the next psalm (compare Psalm 9 title).

Chapter 49

For the choir leader. Of the sons of Korah. A psalm.

1 Hear this, all you peoples!
Give ear, all inhabitants of the world,
2 both low and high,[a]
rich and poor together!
3 My mouth will speak wisdom,
and my heart’s reflection will bring understanding.
4 I will turn my ear to a proverb;
I will open my riddle with the lyre.
5 Why should I be afraid when times are bad,
when the wrongdoing of those who chase me surrounds me,[b]
6 men who rely on their possessions
and glory in the greatness of their riches?
7 None of them can by any means redeem his brother,[c]
nor give God a ransom for him,
8 for the ransom of their soul is costly,
and it fails forever,
9 that he should go on living forever
and not see corruption.
10 Everyone can see that even the wise die;
fools and the senseless perish alike
and leave their riches to others.
11 Their tombs[d] are their houses forever,
their dwellings from generation to generation;
they call their lands by their own names.
12 Man in his splendor does not remain;
he is like the beasts that perish.
13 This is the way of those who are foolish in their confidence,
and of those after them who approve their sayings.
Selah

14 Like sheep they are appointed for Sheol;
death shall shepherd them,
and the upright shall rule over them in the morning.
Their form shall waste away in Sheol,
far from any lofty dwelling.[e]
15 But God will ransom my soul
from the grasp of Sheol,
for he will receive me.
Selah
16 Do not be afraid when a man grows rich,
when the glory of his house increases.
17 For when he dies, he can take nothing with him;
his splendor will not follow him down.
18 Though while he lived he blessed his soul—
and men praise you when you do well for yourself—
19 he shall go to the company of his fathers;
they shall never see the light.
20 Man in his splendor, yet without understanding,
is like the beasts that perish.

Notes

- a (49:2) Hebrew "both sons of man and sons of a man."
- b (49:5) Hebrew "the iniquity of my heels."
- c (49:7) Or "Truly no one can ransom a brother." Some Hebrew manuscripts read "Surely a man cannot ransom himself."
- d (49:11) So the Septuagint and Syriac; the Hebrew has "their inward thought."
- e (49:14) The second half of this verse is very difficult in Hebrew.

Chapter 50

A psalm of Asaph.

1 The Mighty One, God, Yahweh,[b] speaks
and summons the earth
from the rising of the sun to its setting.
2 Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty,
God shines forth.

3 Our God comes and will not stay silent;
fire devours before him,
and round about him the storm rages.
4 He calls to the heavens above
and to the earth, to judge his people:
5 “Assemble to me my godly ones,
those who sealed a covenant with me by sacrifice!”
6 The heavens declare his righteousness,
for God himself is judge!
Selah
7 “Listen, my people, and I will speak;
Israel, I will testify against you.
I am God, your God.
8 I do not reprove you for your sacrifices,
nor for your burnt offerings, ever before me.
9 I will not take a bull from your house
or he-goats from your folds.
10 For every creature of the woods belongs to me,
and the beasts on a thousand hills.
11 I know every bird of the mountains,
and all that moves in the field is mine.
12 If I were hungry, I would not tell you,
for the world and its fullness are mine.
13 Do I eat the flesh of bulls
or drink the blood of goats?
14 Offer thanksgiving as your sacrifice to God,
and keep your vows to the Most High,
15 and call upon me in the day of trouble;
I will rescue you, and you shall glorify me.”
16 But to the wicked man God says:
“What business have you reciting my statutes
or taking my covenant into your mouth?
17 For you loathe instruction
and fling my words behind your back.

18 When you see a thief, you go along with him,
and with adulterers you take your share.
19 Your mouth you let loose for evil,
and your tongue weaves deceit.
20 You sit and speak against your brother;
you slander your own mother's son.
21 These things you did, and I held my peace;
you imagined I was altogether such a one as you.
But I will reprove you and set it all in order before your eyes.
22 "Think about this, you who forget God,
or I will rip you to pieces, with no one to rescue you!
23 He who brings thanksgiving as his offering gives me glory;
and to him who keeps to the right way
I will show the salvation of God!"

Notes

- a (50 title) Asaph was a Levite whom David appointed over the temple singers (1 Chronicles 15:17; 16:5; 25:1), and the name came to be borne by a guild of singers descended from him (Ezra 2:41). Psalms 50 and 73–83 bear his name.
- b (50:1) Hebrew 'el 'elohim YHWH, three names of God set side by side, as in Joshua 22:22.

Chapter 51

For the choir leader. A psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet came to him after he had gone in to Bathsheba.

1 Be gracious to me, O God, according to your covenant love;
according to the greatness of your compassion
wipe away my transgressions.
2 Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity
and make me clean from my sin!
3 For I know my transgressions,
and my sin is before me at all times.
4 You alone are the one I have sinned against;
I have done what is evil in your sight,
so you are right in what you say
and fair in your judgment.[b]

5 Behold, in iniquity I was brought forth,
and in sin my mother conceived me.
6 Behold, you take pleasure in truth in the inner being,
and in the secret place you teach me wisdom.
7 Cleanse me with hyssop,[c] and I shall be clean;
wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.
8 Let me hear gladness and joy;
let the bones you have crushed rejoice.
9 Turn your face away from my sins,
and wipe out all my iniquities.
10 Create a clean heart in me, O God,
and make a steadfast spirit new within me.
11 Do not thrust me from your presence,
and do not remove your Holy Spirit from me.
12 Return to me the joy of your salvation,
and hold me up with a willing spirit.
13 Then I will teach transgressors your ways,
and sinners will turn back to you.
14 Rescue me from bloodguilt, O God,
O God of my salvation,
and my tongue will sing for joy of your righteousness.
15 Lord, open my lips,
and my mouth will declare your praise.
16 You take no pleasure in sacrifice, or I would offer one;
a burnt offering does not please you.
17 The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit;
a broken and crushed heart, O God, you will not despise.
18 In your good pleasure do good to Zion;
build up the walls of Jerusalem.
19 Then you will delight in right sacrifices,
in burnt offering and whole offering;
then bulls will be offered on your altar.

Notes

- a (51 title) See 2 Samuel 11–12. In Hebrew the title is counted as verses 1–2, so Hebrew verse numbers in this psalm are two higher than the English.

- b (51:4) Quoted from the Septuagint in Romans 3:4, "that you may be justified in your words and prevail when you are judged."
- c (51:7) Hyssop, a small bushy plant, was used to sprinkle water and blood in rites of cleansing (Exodus 12:22; Leviticus 14:4–7; Numbers 19:18).

Chapter 52

For the choir leader. A Maskil of David, when Doeg the Edomite came and told Saul, "David has come to the house of Ahimelech."

1 Why do you glory in evil, O mighty man?
The covenant love of God endures all the day.[b]
2 Your tongue plots destruction,
like a sharpened razor, you worker of deceit.
3 You love evil more than good,
lying more than speaking what is right.
Selah
4 You love all words that devour,
O tongue of deceit.
5 God will likewise break you down forever;
he will snatch you and tear you from your tent
and root you out of the land of the living.
Selah
6 The righteous shall see it and fear,
and they shall laugh at him, saying,
7 "See, here is the man who would not make God his stronghold,
but trusted in his great riches
and grew strong in his destruction!"[c]
8 But as for me, I am like a flourishing olive tree in the house of God;
I trust in the covenant love of God forever and ever.
9 I will give you thanks forever for what you have done;
I will wait on your name, for it is good,
in the presence of your faithful ones.

Notes

- a (52 title) See 1 Samuel 21:1–9; 22:9–19. In Hebrew the title is counted as verses 1–2.
- b (52:1) Hebrew "the khesed of God is all the day." The Syriac has "against the godly."

- c (52:7) Or "in his desire," with the Syriac and Targum.

Chapter 53

For the choir leader: according to Mahalath. A Maskil of David.

1 The fool has said in his heart, "There is no God."
They are corrupt; they commit abominable injustice;
there is no one who does good.
2 God looks down from heaven
upon the children of man,
to see if there is any who understands,
who seeks after God.
3 Every one of them has turned back; together they have become rotten;
there is none who does good,
not even one.
4 Have they no knowledge, those workers of iniquity,
who devour my people as they devour bread,
and do not call upon God?
5 They were terrified there,
although there was nothing to be afraid of![b]
God has scattered the bones of those camped around you;
you put them to shame, because God has rejected them.
6 If only Israel's rescue would come from Zion!
When God brings his people back from captivity,[c]
Jacob will celebrate and Israel will be glad.

Notes

- a (53 title) Hebrew mahalat, a word of uncertain meaning, perhaps the name of a tune or a term meaning "sickness" or "sorrow" (also in Psalm 88). This psalm is nearly identical to Psalm 14, but uses "God" (Elohim) where Psalm 14 has "Yahweh," and verse 5 differs.
- b (53:5) Compare Psalm 14:5–6, which reads differently.
- c (53:6) Or "brings back the captivity of his people," as in Psalm 14:7.

Chapter 54

For the choir leader: with stringed instruments. A Maskil of David, when the men of Ziph came and told Saul, "David is hiding with us, is he not?"

1 O God, by your name save me,
and by your power defend my cause.
2 O God, hear my prayer;
give ear to the words of my mouth.
3 For strangers[b] have stood up against me,
and violent men hunt for my life;
they have not set God in front of them.
Selah
4 Behold, God is my helper;
the Lord is the upholder of my life.[c]
5 He will turn back the evil on my enemies;[d]
by your truth make an end of them.
6 With a freewill offering I will sacrifice to you;
I will give thanks to your name, Yahweh, for it is good.
7 For he has delivered me out of all distress,
and my eye has gazed upon my enemies.

Notes

- a (54 title) Hebrew neginot. See 1 Samuel 23:19; 26:1. In Hebrew the title is counted as verses 1–2.
- b (54:3) Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Targum have "arrogant men," as in Psalm 86:14.
- c (54:4) Or "the Lord is among those who uphold my life."
- d (54:5) So the qere; the ketiv has "The evil will return to my enemies."

Chapter 55

For the choir leader: with stringed instruments. A Maskil of David.

1 Listen to my prayer, O God,
and do not hide yourself from my plea!
2 Attend to me and answer me;
I am restless in my complaint, and I moan,
3 at the shouting of the enemy,
at the oppression by the wicked;
for they drop disaster on me
and attack me in rage.
4 My heart writhes within me;
the terrors of death have fallen upon me.

5 Fear and trembling come into me,
and horror has wrapped me round.
6 And I said, "Oh, that I had wings like a dove!
I would fly off and find rest.
7 Yes, I would wander far off
and stay in the desert.
Selah
8 I would make haste to my place of escape
from the raging wind and tempest."
9 Swallow them up, Lord; split their speech;[a]
for I have seen violence and quarreling in the city.
10 Day and night they make the rounds on its walls,
and wickedness and trouble are in its midst;
11 ruin is within it;
oppression and fraud never leave its marketplace.
12 For it was not an enemy who reproached me;
that I could endure;
it was not one who hated me who lifted himself against me;
from him I could have hidden.
13 But it was you, a man of my own rank,
my close friend, whom I knew well.
14 We used to share sweet counsel together;
we walked with the throng in the house of God.
15 Let death come upon them by surprise;
let them go down alive to Sheol![b]
For evil is in their dwelling, in their very midst.
16 But I call to God,
and Yahweh will save me.
17 Evening and morning and noon
I complain and groan,
and he hears my voice.
18 He has ransomed my soul in peace
from the war against me,
for many are against me.

19 God will hear and answer them,
he who sits enthroned of old,
Selah
those who have no changes
and who have no fear of God.
20 That man[c] put forth his hands against those at peace with him;
he broke his covenant.
21 His talk was smoother than cream,
but his heart was set on war;
his words were gentler than oil,
but they were swords out of their sheaths.
22 Throw your burden[d] on Yahweh, and he will sustain you;
he will never let the righteous be shaken.
23 But you, O God, will bring them down
into the pit of destruction;
men of blood and deceit
shall not live out half their days.
But I will trust in you.

Notes

- a (55:9) Compare Genesis 11:1–9.
- b (55:15) Compare Numbers 16:30–33. "Let death come upon them by surprise" follows the qere; the ketiv has "Desolations be upon them."
- c (55:20) Hebrew "He."
- d (55:22) Or "what he has given you." Compare 1 Peter 5:7.

Chapter 56

For the choir leader: according to "The Silent Dove of Distant Places." A Miktam of David, when the Philistines laid hold of him at Gath.

1 Have mercy on me, O God, for man would swallow me up;
the fighter presses me all the day.
2 My watchful foes would swallow me up all day long,
for many are those who war against me proudly.[c]
3 On the day I am afraid,
I put my trust in you.

4 In God I praise his word;
in God I have put my trust; I will not be afraid.
What can flesh do to me?
5 All day long they twist my words;
all their plans are against me for evil.
6 They band together; they lie in ambush;
they watch my heels,
as they have waited for my life.
7 Because of their iniquity, cast them out;[d]
in anger bring down the peoples, O God!
8 You have tallied my wanderings;
place my tears in your flask.
Are they not recorded in your book?
9 Then shall my enemies be turned back
on the day I call;
this I know: God is on my side.
10 In God, whose promise I praise,
in Yahweh, whose promise I praise,
11 I have put my trust in God and will not be afraid.
What can a mere human do to me?
12 Your vows are upon me, O God;
I will render thank offerings to you.
13 For you have delivered my soul from death,
yes, my feet from stumbling,
that I may walk before God
in the light of the living.

Notes

- a (56 title) Hebrew yonat 'elem rehoqim, probably the name of a tune. See 1 Samuel 21:10–15.
- b (56 title) Hebrew miktam, a term of uncertain meaning (also in the titles of Psalms 16 and 57–60).
- c (56:2) Or "O Most High."
- d (56:7) Hebrew "For iniquity, deliverance for them?" The text is difficult.

Chapter 57

For the choir leader: "Do Not Destroy." A Miktam of David, when he fled from Saul, in the cave.

1 Pity me, God, pity me,
for my soul runs to you for safety;
I will find safety under your wings
until the disaster is over.
2 I cry out to God Most High,
to God who brings about his purpose for me.
3 He will send from heaven and save me;
he will shame the one who tramples on me.
Selah
God will send out his covenant love and his faithfulness!
4 My soul is in the midst of lions;
I lie down among those who breathe fire,
the children of man, whose teeth are spears and arrows,
whose tongues are sharp swords.
5 Be exalted, O God, above the heavens!
Let your glory be over all the earth!
6 They spread a net for my feet;
my soul was bent low;
they dug a pit before me,
and into the middle of it they themselves have fallen.
Selah
7 My heart is firm, O God, my heart is firm!
I will sing and make music!
8 Wake up, my glory![b]
Wake up, lute and harp!
I will rouse the dawn!
9 I will give thanks to you, Lord, among the peoples;
I will sing your praise among the nations.
10 For your covenant love is great, reaching to the heavens,
and your faithfulness to the clouds.

11 Be exalted, O God, above the heavens!
Let your glory be over all the earth!

Notes

- a (57 title) Hebrew 'al-tashhet, probably the name of a tune (also in the titles of Psalms 58, 59, and 75). See 1 Samuel 22:1; 24:3. Verses 7–11 appear again as Psalm 108:1–5.
- b (57:8) That is, my soul, or my whole being.

Chapter 58

For the choir leader: "Do Not Destroy." A Miktam of David.

1 Do you indeed speak righteousness, you gods?[a]
Do you judge uprightly the sons of men?
2 No, in your hearts you devise wrongs;
on the earth your hands deal out violence.
3 The wicked go astray from the womb;
liars, they wander off from birth.
4 Their poison is like a snake's poison,
like a deaf adder that stops up its ear,
5 so that it does not hear the voice of the charmers,
of the cunning enchanter.
6 O God, shatter their teeth in their mouth;
break out the jaw teeth of the young lions, Yahweh!
7 Let them flow away like waters that run off;
when he bends his bow, let his arrows be blunted.[b]
8 Let them be like the snail that melts away as it goes,
like a stillborn child that never sees the sun.
9 Before your pots can feel the heat of the thorns,
whether green or burning, may he sweep them away![c]
10 The righteous will rejoice when he sees vengeance;
he will bathe his feet in the blood of the wicked.
11 And mankind will say, "Surely there is a reward for the righteous;
surely there is a God who judges on earth."

Notes

- a (58:1) Hebrew 'elem, "silence," probably to be read 'elim, "gods," that is, rulers or heavenly beings who are set over the nations (compare Psalm 82).
- b (58:7) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.

• c (58:9) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 59

For the choir leader: "Do Not Destroy." A Miktam of David, when Saul sent and they guarded the house to put him to death.

1 Rescue me from my enemies, O my God;
set me high above those who rise against me;
2 rescue me from those who work iniquity,
and save me from men of blood.
3 For behold, they lie in wait for my life;
fierce men band together against me,
not for my transgression nor for my sin, Yahweh,
4 for no guilt of mine they run and make ready.
Rouse yourself to meet me, and see!
5 You, Yahweh, God of Armies, God of Israel,
arise to visit all the nations;
show no mercy to any wicked traitors.
Selah
6 They come back at nightfall;
they snarl like a dog
and go all around the city.
7 Look, they spew out with their mouths,
with swords in their lips—
"for who," they say, "will hear us?"
8 But you, Yahweh, will laugh at them;
you will mock all the nations.
9 O my Strength, I will keep watch for you,[b]
for God is my high tower.
10 My God, who is faithful to me, will come to meet me;[c]
God will let me see my enemies defeated.
11 Do not kill them, or my people may forget;
make them wander by your power and bring them down,
O Lord, our shield!

12 For the sin of their mouth, the word of their lips,
may they be trapped in their pride,
and for the curses and falsehood they tell.
13 Finish them off in wrath; finish them, so they are gone,
and let them know to the ends of the earth
that God is ruler in Jacob.
Selah
14 They come back at nightfall;
they snarl like a dog
and go all around the city.
15 They wander up and down for food,
and if they are not filled, they stay all night.[d]
16 But I will sing about your power;
in the morning I will joyfully sing about your steadfast love.
You have been my stronghold
and my place of safety when I was in trouble.
17 O my Strength, to you I will make music,
for God is my high tower,
the God who shows me covenant love.

Notes

- a (59 title) See 1 Samuel 19:11–17.
- b (59:9) So some Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and the Targum (compare verse 17); most Hebrew manuscripts have "his strength."
- c (59:10) So the qere; the ketiv has "The God of my covenant love."
- d (59:15) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Vulgate read "and grumble."

Chapter 60

For the choir leader: set to "Lily of the Testimony." A Miktam of David, to be taught, when he made war with Aram-naharaim and Aram-zobah, and Joab came back and slew 12,000 of Edom in the Valley of Salt.

1 O God, you have rejected us and broken through our defenses;[c]
you have been angry. Restore us again!
2 You have made the land quake; you have split it open;
mend its cracks, for it totters.
3 You have shown your people harsh things;
you have made us drink a wine of reeling.

4 You have given a banner to those who fear you,
to be raised up because of the truth.[d]
Selah
5 That your beloved ones may be delivered,
save with your right hand and answer us![e]
6 God has spoken in his holiness:[f]
"I will exult; I will divide up Shechem
and measure out the Valley of Succoth.
7 Gilead is mine; Manasseh is mine;
Ephraim is the helmet on my head;
Judah is my scepter.
8 Moab is the basin I wash in;
over Edom I throw my sandal;[g]
over Philistia I raise my shout."
9 Who will bring me into the strong city?
Who will guide me to Edom?
10 Is it not you, O God, who have cast us off?
You, O God, who no longer go out with our armies?
11 Give us help against the adversary,
for vain is the deliverance of man!
12 With God we shall do valiantly;
it is he who will trample our adversaries.

Notes

- a (60 title) Hebrew shushan ʻedut, probably the name of a tune. In Hebrew the title is counted as verses 1–2.
- b (60 title) See 2 Samuel 8:3–14 and 1 Chronicles 18:3–13, where Abishai is credited with 18,000. Verses 5–12 appear again as Psalm 108:6–13.
- c (60:1) Hebrew "broken us."
- d (60:4) Or "that they may flee to it from the bow." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (60:5) So the qere; the ketiv has "answer me."
- f (60:6) Or "in his sanctuary."
- g (60:8) A gesture of taking possession (compare Ruth 4:7).

Chapter 61

For the choir leader: on stringed instruments. Of David.

1 Hear my crying, O God;
give heed to my prayer.
2 From the far end of the earth I call to you
as my heart grows faint.
Lead me to a rock too high for me,
3 for you have been my shelter,
a strong tower against the enemy.
4 Let me be a guest in your tent forever!
Let me shelter under the cover of your wings!
Selah
5 For you, O God, have listened to my vows;
you have given me the heritage of those who fear your name.
6 Add days to the days of the king;
may his years be as generation upon generation!
7 May he sit enthroned before God forever;
appoint covenant love and faithfulness to guard him!
8 So will I sing praise to your name forever,
as I fulfill my vows day after day.

Chapter 62

For the choir leader: according to Jeduthun. A psalm of David.

1 Truly my soul is silent[a] before God alone;
from him comes my salvation.
2 He alone is my rock and my salvation,
my high fortress; I shall not be greatly shaken.
3 How long will you assault a man,
all of you, to batter him down,
as you would a leaning wall, a tottering fence?
4 They only plan to thrust him from his high place;
they take pleasure in falsehood.
With their mouths they bless,
but inwardly they curse.
Selah
5 My soul, be silent before God alone,
for my hope comes from him.

6 He alone is my rock and my salvation,
my high fortress; I shall not be shaken.
7 Upon God rests my salvation and my glory;
my rock of strength, my refuge, is in God.
8 Trust in him at every time, O people;
pour out your hearts before him;
God is a refuge for us.
Selah
9 Men of low birth are only a breath;
men of high birth are a lie;
put on the scales, they go up;
together they weigh less than a breath.
10 Put no trust in extortion;
set no vain hope on robbery;
if riches increase, do not set your heart on them.
11 Once God has spoken;
twice I have heard this:
that power belongs to God,
12 and to you, Lord, belongs covenant love.
For you repay each one according to his deeds.[b]

Notes

- a (62:1) Or "waits in stillness." The word recurs in verse 5.
- b (62:12) Compare Matthew 16:27; Romans 2:6.

Chapter 63

A psalm of David, while he was in the desert of Judah.

1 O God, you are my God; earnestly I search for you;
my soul is thirsty for you;
my body longs for you,
as in a parched and weary land where no water is.
2 Thus I have gazed on you in the holy place,
to see your might and your glory.
3 Because your covenant love is better than life,
my lips shall praise you.

4 Therefore I will bless you all my life;
I will raise my hands in your name.
5 My soul shall be satisfied as with fat and rich food,
and my mouth shall praise you with songs of joy on my lips,
6 when I call you to mind upon my bed
and think on you through the watches of the night;
7 for you have been my help,
and in the shadow of your wings I sing for joy.
8 My soul holds fast to you;
your right hand keeps hold of me.
9 But those who hunt my life to ruin it
will go down to the lowest parts of the earth;
10 they shall be given over to the power of the sword;
they shall be a portion for jackals.
11 But the king will celebrate in God;
all who take oaths in his name will exult,
while the mouths of liars are shut.

Notes

- a (63 title) See 1 Samuel 22:5; 23:14; 2 Samuel 15:23–28.

Chapter 64

For the choir leader. A psalm of David.

1 God, listen to me as I lament;
protect my life from the terror of the enemy.
2 Hide me from the secret plotting of evildoers,
from the throng of those who do iniquity,
3 who whet their tongue like a sword
and fit their arrows, bitter words, to the bow,
4 to shoot in secret at the upright;
all at once they shoot at him and are not afraid.
5 They strengthen themselves in an evil plan;
they talk of laying snares in secret;
they think, "Who will see them?"[a]

6 They search out injustices, saying,
"We have perfected a well-planned scheme!"
For the inward mind and heart of a man are deep.
7 But God will shoot his arrow at them;
suddenly they will be wounded.
8 They will be made to stumble, their own tongues turned against them;
all who see them will shake their heads.
9 And all men will be afraid;
they will declare the work of God
and consider wisely what he has done.
10 The righteous one will rejoice in Yahweh
and take refuge in him.
All the upright in heart will glory!

Notes

- a (64:5) So the Hebrew; some manuscripts and the Syriac have "see us."

Chapter 65

For the choir leader. A psalm of David. A song.

1 Praise waits for you,[a] O God, in Zion,
and to you shall vows be paid.
2 You who listen to prayer,
all flesh will come before you.
3 Deeds of iniquity overpower me;
our transgressions you cover over.
4 Happy is the man whom you choose and draw near
to live in your courts!
We will be filled with the goodness of your house,
your holy temple.
5 You answer us with fearsome acts of justice,
God our savior,
the hope of everyone across the earth
and of those on distant seas;
6 who by his strength set the mountains firm,
being girded with might;

7 who stills the roaring of the seas,
the roaring of their waves,
and the tumult of the peoples,
8 Those who dwell at the earth's far edges stand in awe of your wonders;
the gateways of morning and evening you make to sing for joy.
9 You care for the land and give it water;
you make it very fertile;
God's stream is full of water;
you supply grain for the people,
for this is how you prepare the soil.
10 You drench its furrows,
you level its ridges,
you soften it with showers,
and you bless its growth.
11 You crown the year with your goodness;
your tracks overflow with abundance.[b]
12 The wilderness grasslands drip with plenty,
and the hills are wrapped in rejoicing;
13 the meadows put on flocks like a garment;
the valleys wrap themselves in grain;
they shout for joy; yes, they sing.

Notes

- a (65:1) So the Hebrew vowels ("silence is praise to you"); the Septuagint has "Praise is fitting for you."
- b (65:11) Hebrew "drip with fatness," the image of the wheel ruts of God's chariot spilling plenty as it passes.

Chapter 66

For the choir leader. A song. A psalm.

1 Raise a shout to God, all the earth!
2 Sing out the glory of his name;
make his praise glorious!

3 Say to God, “How fearsome are your works!
Because of your great strength your enemies feign obedience to you.
4 The whole earth worships you;
they sing to you;
they sing out your name.”
Selah
5 Come and look at the works of God,
fearsome in his dealings with the children of man.
6 He turned the sea into dry ground;
they passed through the river on foot.[a]
There we rejoiced in him,
7 He rules forever by his might;
his eyes watch over the nations;
let the rebels not raise themselves up.[b]
Selah
8 O peoples, bless our God;
make the voice of his praise heard,
9 who keeps our soul alive
and has not let our feet be shaken.
10 For you, O God, have tested us;
you have refined us as silver is refined.
11 You led us into the snare;
you put heavy affliction on our loins;
12 you made men ride over our heads;
through fire and through water we went;
then you led us out into abundance.[c]
13 I will come into your house with burnt offerings;
I will pay you my vows,
14 the vows my lips spoke
and my mouth promised when I was in distress.
15 Burnt offerings of fatlings I will bring you,
with the sweet smoke of rams;
bulls with goats I will prepare.
Selah

16 Come and listen, all you who fear God,
and I will tell what he has done for my soul.
17 I called out to him with my mouth,
and his praise was under my tongue.
18 If I had cherished iniquity in my heart,
the Lord would not have listened.
19 But God has indeed heard me;
he has paid attention to my prayer.
20 Blessed be God,
who has not turned away my prayer
or withdrawn his covenant love from me!

Notes

- a (66:6) Compare Exodus 14:21–22; Joshua 3:14–17.
- b (66:7) So the qere; the ketiv has a different form of the verb.
- c (66:12) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint, Syriac, and Jerome have "to a place of refreshment."

Chapter 67

For the choir leader: on stringed instruments. A psalm. A song.

1 May God be gracious to us and bless us
and make his face shine upon us,[a]
Selah
2 so that your way may become known on earth,
your saving power among all the nations.
3 Let the peoples give thanks to you, O God;
let all the peoples give thanks to you!
4 Let the nations be glad and sing aloud,
for you will judge the peoples in uprightness
and guide the nations on the earth.
Selah
5 Let the peoples give thanks to you, O God;
let all the peoples give thanks to you!
6 The earth has yielded its harvest;
God, our God, blesses us.

7 God will bless us,
and all the ends of the earth will fear him.

Notes

- a (67:1) Echoing the priestly blessing of Numbers 6:24–26.

Chapter 68

For the choir leader. Of David. A psalm. A song.

1 God rises up; his enemies scatter;
those who hate him run from his face.[a]
2 As smoke is blown away, so blow them away;
as wax melts at the fire,
so let the wicked perish before God.
3 But let the righteous be glad and exult before God;
let them be jubilant with joy.
4 Sing to God; make music to his name;
build up a highway for him who rides through the deserts;[b]
Yah is his name;[c] exult before him.
5 Father of the fatherless and defender of widows
is God in his holy dwelling.
6 God gives the lonely a home to live in;
he leads out the prisoners into prosperity,
but the rebellious live in a sun-scorched land.
7 O God, when you went out before your people,
when you strode through the wasteland,
Selah
8 the earth trembled; the heavens poured down
before the face of God, the One of Sinai,[d]
before the face of God, the God of Israel.
9 You shed abroad a generous rain, O God;
your inheritance was weary, and you restored it.
10 Your company of creatures[e] settled there;
out of your bounty, O God, you made ready for the afflicted.
11 The Lord gives the word;
the women who bring the news are a great army:[f]

12 “Kings of armies flee, they flee!”
The woman who stays at home divides the plunder.
13 Even as you lie among the sheep pens,[g]
a dove’s wings are plated with silver,
her pinions with a greenish gleam of gold.
14 As Shaddai[h] scattered the kings in it,
it was snowing on Zalmon.[i]
15 A mountain of God is Bashan’s mountain;
a mountain of many summits is Bashan’s mountain!
16 Why do you look with envy, you many-peaked mountains,
on the mount that God desired for his dwelling?
Yes, Yahweh will dwell there forever.
17 God’s chariots number twenty thousand, thousands repeated;
the Lord is in their midst; Sinai is in holiness.[j]
18 You went up to the height; you led captives captive;
you received gifts among men,
even among the rebellious, that Yah God might dwell there.[k]
19 Blessed be the Lord, who carries us[l] day by day,
the God who is our salvation.
Selah
20 Our God is a God of saving acts,
and to Yahweh the Lord belong the ways out from death.
21 Surely God will crush the heads of his enemies,
the hairy crown of him who walks on in his guilt.
22 The Lord has said, “From Bashan I will bring back;
I will bring back from the deep places of the sea,
23 that you may strike your foot in blood,[m]
and the tongues of your dogs may have their share of the enemy.”
24 Your processions are seen, O God,
the processions of my God, my King, into the sanctuary:
25 singers in front, musicians last,
between them young women playing tambourines:
26 “In the great assemblies bless God,
bless Yahweh, you who are from Israel’s fountain!”

27 There is little Benjamin, in front, ruling over them;
there are the leaders of Judah with their crowd,
the leaders of Zebulun and the leaders of Naphtali.
28 Your God has commanded your strength;[n]
show your strength, O God, you who have acted for us.
29 Because of your temple above Jerusalem,
kings will bring gifts to you.
30 Rebuke the beast among the reeds,[o]
the herd of bulls with the calves of the peoples,
trampling those who delight in silver;[p]
scatter the peoples who take pleasure in war.
31 Envoys will come from Egypt;
Cush[q] will hurry to stretch out her hands to God.
32 Kingdoms of the earth, sing to God;
make music to the Lord,
Selah
33 to him who rides in the heavens, the ancient heavens;
see, he sends out his voice, a voice of power.
34 Ascribe power to God;
his splendor rests over Israel,
and his might is in the clouds.
35 You are awe-inspiring, God, in your sanctuary;
the God of Israel gives power and strength to his people.
Praise God!

Notes

- a (68:1) Compare Numbers 10:35, the cry when the ark set out.
- b (68:4) Or "extol him who rides on the clouds." Hebrew ʿarabot, "desert plains"; compare verse 33.
- c (68:4) Yah is the short form of the name Yahweh; compare Exodus 15:2.
- d (68:8) Or "even Sinai quaked." Compare Judges 5:4–5.
- e (68:10) Hebrew khayyah, "living things," perhaps here "your flock" or "your people."
- f (68:11) The Hebrew participle is feminine; compare Exodus 15:20; 1 Samuel 18:6.
- g (68:13) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; compare Judges 5:16.
- h (68:14) Shaddai, traditionally "the Almighty."

- i (68:14) Zalmon is a hill near Shechem (Judges 9:48), or "it snowed in the darkness." The verse is obscure.
- j (68:17) Or "the Lord has come from Sinai into the holy place," with a slight change to the Hebrew.
- k (68:18) Ephesians 4:8 quotes this line in the form "gave gifts to men," agreeing with the Aramaic Targum and the Syriac.
- l (68:19) Or "who bears our burdens."
- m (68:23) So the Hebrew ("crush"); the Septuagint and Syriac have "dip your foot."
- n (68:28) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint, Syriac, and some Hebrew manuscripts have "Command your strength, O God."
- o (68:30) Probably Egypt, pictured as a crocodile or hippopotamus.
- p (68:30) Or "until each one submits with bars of silver." The Hebrew is very difficult.
- q (68:31) The upper Nile region, south of Egypt.

Chapter 69

For the choir leader: according to "Lilies." Of David.

1 Rescue me, O God,
for the waters have reached my throat.[a]
2 I have sunk in deep mud,
and there is no foothold;
I have come into the depths of the waters,
and the flood sweeps over me.
3 I am weary from calling out; my throat is dry;
my eyes fail as I wait for my God.
4 There are more people who hate me for nothing[b]
than hairs on my head;
my attackers, my lying enemies, are strong.
Must I repay
what I never took?
5 You, O God, know my foolishness,
and my guilty deeds are not concealed from you.
6 Let none who wait for you be ashamed on my account,
Lord Yahweh of Armies;
let none who seek you be humiliated on my account,
O God of Israel.

7 For your sake I have endured insult;
disgrace has covered my face.
8 I have become a stranger to my brothers,
a foreigner to the sons of my mother.
9 Zeal for your house has eaten me up,[c]
and the scorn of those who scorn you has fallen on me.[d]
10 When I wept, with my soul in fasting,
that became a reproach against me.
11 When I made sackcloth my clothing,
I became a byword to them.
12 Those who sit at the gate talk about me,
and drunkards make songs about me.
13 But as for me, my prayer is to you, Yahweh,
at a time of favor.
O God, in the abundance of your covenant love,
answer me with your sure salvation.
14 Pull me out of the mud, and do not let me sink;
let me be rescued from those who hate me
and from the deep waters.
15 Do not let the flood overwhelm me
or the deep swallow me up
or the pit shut its mouth on me.
16 Answer me, Yahweh, for your covenant love is good;
in the greatness of your compassion turn to me.
17 Do not hide your face from your servant,
for I am in distress; quickly answer me.
18 Come near to my soul and redeem it;
ransom me because of my enemies.
19 You know the insults I bear,
my shame and my dishonor;
all my adversaries are in your sight.
20 Insults have broken my heart, and I am sick;
I looked for pity, but there was none,
for comforters, but I found no one.

21 They put poison[e] in my food,
and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink.[f]
22 Let their table before them become a trap,
and for those at ease, a snare.[g]
23 Let their eyes grow dark so they cannot see,
and make their loins shake without ceasing.
24 Pour out your fury on them,
and let the heat of your anger catch them.
25 Let their camp become a ruin;
let no one live in their tents.[h]
26 For they persecute the one you have struck,
and they recount the pain of those you have wounded.
27 Add guilt to their guilt;
let them have no share in your righteousness.
28 Let them be blotted from the book of life;
let them not be written down with the righteous.
29 But I am lowly and in sorrow;
let your saving help, O God, set me on high.
30 I will praise the name of God in a song
and glorify him with thanksgiving.
31 This will please Yahweh better than an ox,
a young bull with horns and split hoofs.
32 The lowly have seen and rejoice;
you seekers of God, may your heart live.
33 For Yahweh listens to the needy
and does not scorn his own who are captive.
34 Let heaven and earth praise him,
the seas and everything that moves in them.
35 For God will save Zion
and rebuild the cities of Judah,
and they shall live there and possess it;
36 the children of his servants will inherit it,
and those who love his name will live there.

Notes

- a (69:1) Hebrew nephesh, here in its basic sense of “throat” or “neck.”
- b (69:4) Quoted in John 15:25.
- c (69:9) Quoted in John 2:17.
- d (69:9) Quoted in Romans 15:3.
- e (69:21) Hebrew rosh, a bitter, poisonous plant; the Septuagint has “gall.”
- f (69:21) Compare Matthew 27:34, 48; John 19:28–29.
- g (69:22) Or “and their peace offerings a snare.” Verses 22–23 are quoted in Romans 11:9–10, following the Septuagint.
- h (69:25) Quoted in Acts 1:20.

Chapter 70

For the choir leader. Of David. For a memorial offering.

1 O God, hurry to rescue me!
Yahweh, hurry to help me!
2 Let them be shamed and put to confusion
who seek after my life!
Let them be driven back and humiliated
who take pleasure in my hurt!
3 Let those who cry, “Aha, aha!”
be turned back as the wage of their shame.
4 May all who seek you
be glad and rejoice in you!
May those who love your salvation
always say, “God is great!”
5 But I am afflicted and needy;
hurry to me, O God!
You are my help and the one who sets me free;
Yahweh, do not delay!

Notes

- a (70 title) Compare the title of Psalm 38. This psalm closely matches Psalm 40:13–17. In Hebrew numbering the title is verse 1, so the Hebrew has six verses.

Chapter 71

1 In you, Yahweh, I have found refuge;[a]
let me never be shamed.
2 By your righteousness rescue me and set me free;
bend your ear to me and save me.

3 Be a rock of dwelling for me,
where I may always come;
you have given the command to save me,
for you are my rock and my stronghold.
4 My God, rescue me from the hand of the wicked,
from the grasp of the unjust and the ruthless.
5 For you are my hope, Lord Yahweh,
my confidence from my youth.
6 On you I have leaned from birth;
you are the one who brought me from my mother's womb;[b]
my praise is always of you.
7 I have become like a portent to many,
but you are my strong refuge.
8 My mouth is full of your praise,
of your splendor all day long.
9 Do not throw me away when I am old;
do not abandon me as my strength fails.
10 For my enemies talk against me;
those who watch for my life plot together,
11 saying, "God has left him;
chase him and seize him,
for no one will rescue him."
12 O God, do not stay far from me;
my God, hurry to my help![c]
13 Let my accusers be shamed and consumed;
let those who seek my harm
be wrapped in insult and disgrace.
14 But I will always hope
and will praise you more and more.
15 My mouth will tell of your righteousness,
of your saving deeds all the day,
though their number is past my knowing.
16 I will come with the mighty acts of the Lord Yahweh;
I will make mention of your righteousness, yours alone.

17 O God, you have taught me since my youth,
and until now I proclaim your wonders.
18 And now, when I am old and gray-haired,
O God, do not forsake me,
till I declare your arm to this generation,
your power to everyone yet to come.
19 Your righteousness, O God, reaches the heights;
you have done great things;
O God, who is like you?
20 You who have shown me[d] many bitter troubles
will make me live once more;
from the deeps of the earth
you will raise me up again.
21 You will increase my greatness
and turn again to comfort me.
22 I also will praise you with the harp
for your faithfulness, my God;
I will make music to you with the lyre,
O Holy One of Israel.
23 My lips will shout for joy when I make music to you,
and my soul, which you have redeemed.
24 My tongue will also tell of your righteousness all day,
for those who tried to hurt me
have been shamed and humiliated.

Notes

- a (71:1) This psalm has no title. Verses 1–3 closely follow Psalm 31:1–3.
- b (71:6) Or "who cut the cord," an uncertain Hebrew word.
- c (71:12) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant spelling.
- d (71:20) So the qere throughout this verse; the ketiv has "us."

Chapter 72

Of Solomon.

1 God, give your decisions to the king,
and your righteousness to the king's son.

2 May he judge your people with righteousness
and your afflicted ones with justice.
3 Let the mountains bear peace for the people,
and the hills, through righteousness.
4 May he do justice for the lowly among the people,
save the sons of the needy,
and break the oppressor in pieces.
5 May they fear you[b] while the sun endures,
and as long as the moon, through all generations.
6 May he be like rain falling on the mown field,
like showers that water the land.
7 Let the righteous flourish in his days,
and let there be much peace until the moon is gone.
8 May he rule from sea to sea,
and from the River[c] to the ends of the earth.
9 May the desert dwellers bow down before him,
and his enemies lick the dust.
10 May the kings of Tarshish and of the coastlands
render tribute;
may the kings of Sheba and Seba
bring gifts.
11 May all kings fall down before him,
all nations serve him.
12 For he rescues the needy who cry out,
the afflicted, and the one who has no helper.
13 He will spare the poor and needy one
and will save the souls of the needy.
14 From oppression and violence he redeems their lives,
and their blood is precious in his eyes.
15 So may he live, and may Sheba's gold be given him;
may they pray for him continually
and bless him all day long.
16 Let there be an abundance of grain in the land,
waving on the mountaintops;

let its fruit sway like Lebanon,
and let those of the city blossom like the grass of the earth.
17 May his name last forever;
may his fame[d] continue as long as the sun shines!
May every nation find blessing through him[e]
and call him fortunate!
18 Blessed be Yahweh God, the God of Israel,
who alone does wonders.
19 May his glorious name be praised forever;
may his glory fill the whole earth!
Amen and amen![f]
20 The prayers of David the son of Jesse are ended.[g]

Notes

- a (72 title) Or "For Solomon." A prayer for the king, closing Book Two.
- b (72:5) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has "May he endure."
- c (72:8) The Euphrates.
- d (72:17) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant form, "sprout."
- e (72:17) Compare Genesis 12:3; 22:18.
- f (72:19) Verses 18–19 are the doxology that closes Book Two of the Psalms; compare 41:13; 89:52; 106:48; and Psalm 150.
- g (72:20) An editorial note closing an earlier collection of David's psalms; some psalms of David still follow (for example, 86, 101, 103, 108–110, 138–145).

Chapter 73

Book Three (Psalms 73–89)

A psalm of Asaph.

1 Surely God is good to Israel,
to those who are pure of heart.
2 But as for me, my feet had nearly turned aside;[b]
my steps had all but slid away.
3 For I grew jealous of the boastful
when I watched the wicked prosper.
4 For they have no pangs until their death;[c]
their bodies are sleek and fat.
5 They have no share in the toil of mortals;
they are not struck down as other people are.

6 So pride is their necklace;
violence wraps them like a robe.
7 Their eyes bulge out from fatness;[d]
the fancies of their hearts overflow.
8 They jeer and speak with malice;
from on high they talk of oppression.
9 They have set their mouths against the heavens,
and their tongues strut across the earth.
10 Therefore his people turn back to them,[e]
and they drain waters in full measure.[f]
11 And they say, "How does God know?
Is there knowledge with the Most High?"
12 Look at them: these are the wicked,
always at ease; they pile up wealth.
13 In vain, then, I have kept my heart pure
and bathed my hands in innocence.
14 For I have been struck all day long,
and my rebuke comes every morning.
15 If I had said, "I will talk like this,"
I would have betrayed the generation of your children.
16 But when I set myself to understand this,
it was a weary task in my eyes,
17 until I entered the sanctuaries of God;[g]
then I perceived their end.
18 Truly you place them on slippery ground;
you hurl them down to ruin.
19 How suddenly they become a desolation,
swept away entirely by terrors!
20 Like a dream after one wakes, Lord,
so when you rouse yourself you will despise their phantoms.
21 When my heart was soured
and I was stabbed in my inward parts,[h]
22 I was stupid and did not understand;
I was a brute beast toward you.

23 Still, I am with you continually;
you hold me by my right hand.
24 You will lead me with your counsel,
and afterward you will receive me with glory.[i]
25 Whom do I have in heaven but you?
And besides you I want nothing on earth.
26 My flesh and my heart may waste away,
but God is the rock[j] of my heart and my portion forever.
27 For look: those far from you will be lost;
you silence all who go whoring away from you.
28 But as for me, nearness to God is my good;
I have made the Lord Yahweh my refuge,
that I may tell of all your works.

Notes

- a (73 title) Book Three of the Psalms begins here; it closes with the doxology at 89:52. Psalms 73–83 form a collection attributed to Asaph, a Levite singer appointed by David (1 Chronicles 15:17–19; 16:4–7; 25:1–2); compare Psalm 50. Psalms 84–85 and 87–88 belong to the sons of Korah.
- b (73:2) So the qere for both verbs; the ketiv has variant forms.
- c (73:4) Or, dividing the Hebrew differently, "they have no pangs; sound and fat is their body."
- d (73:7) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Syriac have "their iniquity comes out from fatness."
- e (73:10) So the ketiv; the qere has "he brings back his people here."
- f (73:10) The meaning of the Hebrew in this verse is uncertain.
- g (73:17) Or "the holy things of God."
- h (73:21) Hebrew "kidneys," the seat of the emotions.
- i (73:24) Or "take me to glory."
- j (73:26) Hebrew tsur, "rock."

Chapter 74

A Maskil of Asaph.

1 Why, O God, have you rejected us forever?
Why does your anger smoke against the sheep you pasture?
2 Remember your assembly, which you acquired long ago,
the tribe of your inheritance, which you redeemed,
Mount Zion, where you have made your dwelling.

3 Lift your steps toward the endless ruins,
everything the enemy has wrecked in the holy place.
4 Your foes have roared in the middle of your meeting place;
they have set up their own banners as signs.
5 They looked like men swinging axes
upward into a thicket of trees.[b]
6 And now all its carved panels[c]
they smash with hatchet and hammers.
7 They have set your sanctuary on fire;
they have profaned the dwelling of your name, bringing it to the ground.
8 They said in their hearts, “Let us crush them altogether”;
they burned every meeting place of God in the land.
9 We do not see our signs;
there is no longer a prophet,
and none among us knows how long.
10 How long, O God, will the foe taunt?
Is the enemy to scorn your name forever?
11 Why do you hold back your hand, your right hand?
Take it out of the fold of your garment[d] and finish them off!
12 Yet God has been my King since long ago,
bringing rescue across the land.
13 You split the sea by your might;
you shattered the heads of the sea monsters on the waters.
14 You crushed the heads of Leviathan;[e]
you gave him as food to the people of the wilderness.[f]
15 You split open fountain and stream;
you made the ever-running rivers dry.
16 The day belongs to you, and the night is yours as well;
you established the moon[g] and the sun.
17 You fixed all the boundaries of the earth;
summer and winter you formed.
18 Remember this, Yahweh: the enemy taunts,
and a foolish people scorns your name.

19 Do not hand over your turtledove's soul to the wild beast;
do not forget forever the life of your poor.
20 Look to the covenant,
for the dark corners of the land are full of the haunts of violence.
21 Let not the downtrodden turn back in disgrace;
let the poor and needy praise your name.
22 Rise up, O God, argue your own case;
remember how the fool taunts you all day long.
23 Do not forget the clamor of your adversaries,
the din of those rising up against you, ascending continually.

Notes

- a (74 title) A lament over the destruction of the sanctuary, most likely by the Babylonians in 587 BC (2 Kings 25:8–9). On Maskil, see Psalm 32.
- b (74:5) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (74:6) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant spelling.
- d (74:11) So the qere; the ketiv has "your statute."
- e (74:14) A many-headed sea serpent, a picture of chaos; compare Job 41; Isaiah 27:1.
- f (74:14) Or "to the creatures of the desert."
- g (74:16) Hebrew "the light," probably the moon.

Chapter 75

To the director: set to "Destroy Not." A psalm of Asaph; a song.

1 To you, O God, we give thanks, we give thanks;
and near is your name;[a]
they recount your wonderful works.
2 "When I seize the appointed time,
I myself will judge with equity.
3 When the earth and all who live on it reel,
it is I who keep its pillars steady.
Selah
4 To the arrogant I say, 'Stop your boasting,'
and to the wicked, 'Do not lift up the horn;[b]
5 do not lift your horn on high,
or speak with an arrogant neck.'"

6 For promotion comes not from the east or the west
or from the wilderness;[c]
7 but it is God who judges,
bringing one low and lifting another up.
8 For Yahweh holds a cup in his hand;
the wine in it foams and is mixed with spices,
and he pours it out;
9 But I will declare it forever;
I will sing praises to the God of Jacob.
10 "All the horns of the wicked I will cut off,
but the horns of the righteous will be raised high."

Notes

- a (75:1) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has "we will call on your name."
- b (75:4) The horn is a picture of strength and pride; so also in verses 5 and 10.
- c (75:6) Or "not from the desert of the mountains."

Chapter 76

For the choir leader: with stringed instruments. A psalm of Asaph. A song.

1 In Judah God is known;
his name is great in Israel.
2 His shelter[a] has been set up in Salem,[b]
his lair in Zion.
3 There he shattered the fiery shafts of the bow,
the shield and sword and battle gear.
Selah
4 Radiant are you,
more majestic than the mountains of prey.[c]
5 The stouthearted were stripped of their spoil;
they sank into their sleep;
none of the men of war could find their hands.
6 At your rebuke, O God of Jacob,
both chariot and horse lay stunned.
7 You—you are to be feared!
Who can stand before you once your anger is roused?

8 From the heavens you made your judgment heard;
the earth was afraid and fell silent
9 when God rose up to judge,
to save all the humble of the earth.
Selah
10 Surely the wrath of man will praise you;
with the remnant of wrath you will gird yourself.[d]
11 Make vows to Yahweh your God and keep them;
let all around him bring tribute to the One to be feared,
12 who cuts short the breath of princes,
who is fearsome to the kings of the earth.

Notes

- a (76:2) Or "his booth," the image of a lion's thicket.
- b (76:2) An old name for Jerusalem; compare Genesis 14:18.
- c (76:4) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has "the everlasting mountains."
- d (76:10) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 77

For the choir leader: according to Jeduthun. Of Asaph. A psalm.

1 My voice goes up to God, and I cry out;
my voice goes up to God, and he will listen to me.
2 When I was in trouble I looked for the Lord;
at night I reached out my hand and did not grow tired;
my soul refused to be comforted.
3 I think of God, and I groan;
I ponder, and my spirit faints.
Selah
4 You hold my eyelids open;
I am so troubled I cannot speak.
5 I consider the days long past,
the years of ages gone by.
6 I call to mind my song in the night;
I muse with my heart,
and my spirit searches:

7 “Will the Lord cast off for all time
and be favorable no more?
8 Has his covenant love come to an end for all time?
Is his promise at an end for all generations?
9 Has God forgotten to be gracious?
Has he in anger shut off his compassion?”
Selah
10 Then I said, “What hurts me most
is that the right hand of the Most High is different now.”[b]
11 I will call to mind the deeds of Yah;[c]
yes, I will remember your wonders of old.
12 I will think over everything you have done
and reflect on your mighty deeds.
13 O God, your way is in holiness.
What god is great like our God?
14 You are the God who works wonders;
you have made your strength known among the peoples.
15 By your arm you have ransomed your people,
Jacob’s sons and Joseph’s.
Selah
16 The waters saw you, O God;
the waters saw you and writhed;
the very deeps trembled.
17 The clouds poured down water;
the skies gave a thundering voice;
your arrows flashed back and forth.
18 Your thunder’s voice rolled in the whirlwind;
lightnings lit the world;
the earth trembled and shook.
19 Your road was in the sea,
your paths in the mighty waters,
and your tracks could not be known.
20 You led your people like a flock
by the hand of Moses and Aaron.

Notes

- a (77 title) So the qere; the ketiv has "Jeduthun" spelled differently. Compare Psalm 39 and 62.
- b (77:10) Or "I will appeal to the years of the right hand of the Most High." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (77:11) So the qere ("I will make mention of the deeds of Yah"); Yah is the short form of the name Yahweh.

Chapter 78

A Maskil of Asaph.

1 My people, hear my instruction;[b]
listen closely to what I say.
2 I will open my mouth in a parable;
I will pour out riddles from long ago,[c]
3 things we have heard and known,
which our fathers have recounted to us.
4 We will not hide them from their descendants
but will tell the next generation
about the praiseworthy acts of Yahweh, his power,
and the wonders he has performed.
5 He set up a testimony in Jacob
and placed a law in Israel,
which he commanded our fathers
to teach to their children,
6 so that a later generation might know them,
children not yet born,
and rise up and recount them to their own children,
7 that they might place their hope in God,
not forgetting the works of God,
but guarding his commands;
8 and that they should not be like their fathers,
a generation stubborn and defiant,
a generation whose heart was not steady,
whose spirit was not faithful to God.
9 The men of Ephraim, armed archers,[d]
turned back on the day of battle.

10 They did not keep God's covenant
and would not walk in his law.
11 They let his deeds slip from memory,
and the marvels he had let them see.
12 In the sight of their fathers he did marvels
in the land of Egypt, in the region of Zoan.[e]
13 He split the sea and let them pass through;
he made the waters stand up like a heap.
14 By day he led them with a cloud,
and all night long with the light of fire.
15 He split rocks in the wilderness
and gave them drink as from the great deep.
16 He brought streams out of the crag
and made waters flow down like rivers.
17 Yet they went on sinning still more against him,
defying the Most High in the desert.
18 They put God to the test in their hearts
by demanding the food they craved.
19 They spoke against God, saying,
"Can God lay out a table in the wilderness?
20 True, he struck the rock and waters gushed
and torrents overflowed;
but can he also give bread
or supply meat for his people?"
21 So when Yahweh heard, he was furious;
a fire was lit against Jacob,
and anger also rose against Israel,
22 because they did not believe in God
or trust his power to save.
23 Yet he gave orders to the skies above
and opened the doors of heaven;
24 he rained manna on them to eat
and gave them the grain of heaven.

25 Mortals ate the bread of the mighty;[f]
he sent them food in abundance.
26 He roused the east wind across the sky
and guided the south wind by his might;
27 He showered flesh on them like dust,
and birds on the wing like sea sand;
28 he let them fall in the middle of their camp,
all around their dwellings.
29 So they ate and were thoroughly filled,
for he gave them what they craved.
30 They had not yet turned from their lust;
their food was still in their mouths
31 the anger of God rose against them;
he killed the sturdiest of them
and struck down Israel's young men.[g]
32 In spite of all this they sinned again;
they did not believe in his wonders.
33 So he ended their days like a breath,
and their years in sudden terror.
34 Whenever he killed some, the rest would seek him;
they would turn back and search eagerly for God.
35 They remembered that God was their rock,
and God Most High their redeemer.
36 But they flattered him with their mouths
and lied to him with their tongues.
37 For their heart was not steadfast with him;
they kept no faith with his covenant.
38 Yet he, being compassionate,
covered over their guilt and did not destroy them;
again and again he held back his anger
and did not rouse all his wrath.
39 He remembered that they were only flesh,
a breath that passes and does not come back.

40 How often they defied him in the wilderness
and grieved him in the desert!
41 Again and again they put God to the test
and grieved[h] Israel's Holy One.
42 They gave no thought to his hand,
to the day he redeemed them from the adversary,
43 when he set his signs in Egypt
and his marvels in the region of Zoan.
44 He turned their rivers to blood,
so they could not drink from their streams.
45 He sent among them mixed swarms that ate them up,
and frogs that brought them ruin.
46 He handed their harvest to the caterpillar
and the fruit of their work to the locust.
47 He killed their vines with hail
and their sycamore figs with frost.[i]
48 He handed over their cattle to the hail
and their herds to bolts of fire.
49 He let loose on them his burning anger,
fury, indignation, and distress,
a band of messengers of disaster.
50 He leveled a road for his wrath;
he did not hold back their soul from death
but handed their life to pestilence.
51 He struck every firstborn son in Egypt,
the beginning of their vigor, in the tents of Ham.[j]
52 Then he brought out his people like sheep
and guided them in the wilderness like a flock.
53 He led them in safety, and they were not afraid,
but the sea covered over their enemies.
54 He led them to the border of his holy place,
to this mountain, which his right hand acquired.

55 He drove out nations before them;
he allotted them a heritage by measuring line
and settled the tribes of Israel in their tents.
56 Yet they tested and defied God Most High
and did not keep his testimonies.
57 They turned away and were faithless like their fathers;
they swerved like a bow that cannot be trusted.
58 They angered him with their high places;
they stirred his jealousy with their carved idols.
59 When God heard, he was furious
and utterly rejected Israel.
60 He forsook the tabernacle of Shiloh,[k]
the tent he had pitched among men,
61 and gave up his strength[l] to captivity,
his splendor into the hand of the foe.
62 He gave his people over to the sword
and was furious with his inheritance.
63 Fire devoured their young men,
and no marriage song was sung for their maidens.
64 Their priests fell by the sword,
and their widows could not weep.[m]
65 Then the Lord awoke like one who had slept,
like a mighty man shouting from wine.
66 He beat his foes back;
he gave them lasting disgrace.
67 He refused Joseph's tent
and did not select Ephraim's tribe,
68 but he chose the tribe of Judah,
Mount Zion, which he loves.
69 He built his sanctuary like the heights,[n]
like the earth, which he founded forever.
70 He chose David his servant
and took him from the sheep pens;

71 from following the ewes with lambs he brought him
to be shepherd of Jacob his people,
and of Israel his heritage.
72 He shepherded them with integrity of heart
and led them with skillful hands.

Notes

- a (78 title) A long teaching psalm recounting Israel's history from the exodus to David; compare Psalms 105 and 106.
- b (78:1) Hebrew torah, "instruction."
- c (78:2) Quoted in Matthew 13:35.
- d (78:9) Hebrew "armed ones, shooters of the bow."
- e (78:12) Tanis, a city in the eastern Nile delta.
- f (78:25) Or "the bread of angels," as in the Septuagint.
- g (78:31) Compare Numbers 11:31–34.
- h (78:41) Or "provoked" or "set limits for"; the meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain.
- i (78:47) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- j (78:51) Ham is a poetic name for Egypt (Genesis 10:6).
- k (78:60) Compare 1 Samuel 4; Jeremiah 7:12–14.
- l (78:61) The ark of the covenant; compare Psalm 132:8.
- m (78:64) Compare 1 Samuel 4:11, 19–22.
- n (78:69) Or "like the high heavens."

Chapter 79

A psalm of Asaph.

1 O God, the nations have invaded your inheritance;
they have made your holy temple unclean;
they have turned Jerusalem into heaps of rubble.
2 They have left the corpses of your servants
as food for the birds of the sky,
the flesh of your faithful ones for the beasts of the land.
3 Their blood they have spilled like water
on every side of Jerusalem,
with no one to bury them.
4 We are a reproach to those who live near us,
a joke and a scorn to those all about us.

5 How long, Yahweh? Will you be angry forever?
Will your jealousy go on burning like fire?
6 Pour out your fury on the nations that do not know you,
and on the realms that never call upon your name;
7 for they have eaten up Jacob
and laid his pasture waste.
8 Do not remember against us the sins of former days;[a]
let your mercies hurry to meet us,
for we are laid very low.
9 Help us, God of our salvation,
for your name's glory;
deliver us and cover our sins
because of your name.
10 Why should the nations say,
"Where is their God?"
Let the avenging of your servants' shed blood
be made known among the nations before our eyes.
11 Let the groaning of the captive come before you;
by the greatness of your arm
spare those condemned to die.[b]
12 Pay back into the laps[c] of our neighbors sevenfold
the taunts with which they taunted you, Lord.
13 Then we, your people and the sheep you pasture,
will give you thanks forever;
to every generation we will tell your praise.

Notes

- a (79:8) Or "our former iniquities."
- b (79:11) Hebrew "the sons of death."
- c (79:12) Hebrew "bosom," the fold of a garment used as a pocket.

Chapter 80

For the choir leader: according to "Lilies." A testimony. Of Asaph. A psalm.

1 Shepherd of Israel, give ear,
you who lead Joseph like a flock!
You who are enthroned upon the cherubim,[a] shine out
2 before Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh!
Awaken your might
and come to save us!
3 Restore us, O God;
let your face shine, and we will be saved.[b]
4 Yahweh, God of Armies,
how long will you smolder at the prayer of your people?
5 You have fed them bread made of tears
and given them tears to drink by the measure.[c]
6 You make us a cause of strife to our neighbors,
and our enemies jeer among themselves.
7 God of Armies, restore us;
let your face shine, and we will be saved.
8 You brought a vine out of Egypt;
you drove out the nations and planted it.
9 You cleared the ground before it;
it struck deep roots and filled the land.
10 Its shade covered the mountains,
and its branches the mighty cedars.[d]
11 It stretched out its shoots as far as the Sea,
its tendrils to the River.[e]
12 Why have you torn down its walls,
so that all who pass along the road strip its fruit?
13 The boar from the forest gnaws it,
and whatever moves in the field feeds on it.
14 God of Armies, come back, we pray!
Look down from heaven and see;
take care of this vine,
15 the stock[f] that your right hand planted,
and the son you made strong for yourself.

16 It is burned with fire, cut down;
may they perish at the rebuke of your face!
17 Let your hand rest on the man at your right,
on the human being you made strong for yourself.
18 Then we will not turn away from you;
give us life, and we will call on your name.
19 Yahweh, God of Armies, restore us;
let your face shine, and we will be saved.

Notes

- a (80:1) The winged figures over the ark of the covenant; compare Exodus 25:18–22.
- b (80:3) This refrain recurs, growing fuller, in verses 7 and 19.
- c (80:5) Hebrew shalish, "a third," a measure of perhaps a third of an ephah.
- d (80:10) Hebrew "the cedars of God."
- e (80:11) The Mediterranean and the Euphrates.
- f (80:15) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.

Chapter 81

For the choir leader: on the Gittith. Of Asaph.

1 Shout for joy to God our strength;
raise a glad cry to the God of Jacob!
2 Lift up a song and strike the tambourine,
the sweet lyre together with the harp.
3 Blow the ram's horn at the new moon,
at the full moon, on the day of our feast.[b]
4 For it is a statute for Israel,
an ordinance of the God of Jacob.
5 He established it as a decree for Joseph
when he marched out against[c] the land of Egypt.
I heard a language I did not know:[d]
6 "I took the load off his shoulder;
his hands were freed from the basket.[e]
7 You called in trouble, and I rescued you;
I answered you from where the thunder hides;
I put you to the test at the waters of Meribah.[f]
Selah

8 Listen, my people, and I will give you a warning—
Israel, if only you would pay attention to me!
9 You must not have any foreign god among you;
you must not worship a strange god.
10 I am Yahweh your God,
who brought you up from the land of Egypt.
Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.
11 "But my people did not heed my voice;
Israel would have none of me.
12 So I let them go in the stubbornness of their hearts,
to walk by their own schemes.
13 Oh, if my people would listen to me,
if Israel would walk in my ways,
14 how swiftly I would humble their enemies
and turn my hand against their foes!
15 Those who hate Yahweh would cringe before him,
and their doom[g] would last forever.
16 But he would feed you[h] with the best of the wheat,
and I would fill you with honey out of the rock."

Notes

- a (81 title) See the title of Psalm 8.
- b (81:3) Probably the Feast of Booths in the seventh month (Leviticus 23:24, 34).
- c (81:5) Or "over."
- d (81:5) Or "I heard a language I did not know."
- e (81:6) The basket for carrying clay or bricks; compare Exodus 1:11–14.
- f (81:7) Meribah means "quarreling"; compare Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 20:1–13.
- g (81:15) Hebrew "their time."
- h (81:16) Hebrew "him," that is, Israel.

Chapter 82

A psalm of Asaph.

1 God stands in the divine council;[a]
in the midst of the gods he gives judgment:
2 "How long will you judge unjustly
and show favor to the wicked?
Selah

3 Give justice to the weak and the fatherless;
uphold the right of the afflicted and the destitute.
4 Set free the weak and the poor;
snatch them from the grip of the wicked."
5 They neither know nor understand;
they walk about in darkness;
all the foundations of the earth are shaken.
6 "I said, 'You are gods,
sons of the Most High, all of you;
7 Yet you will die as mortals die
and fall like one of the rulers.'"
8 Rise up, O God, and judge the earth,
because all the nations are your inheritance!

Notes

- a (82:1) Hebrew ʿadat-ʾel, "the assembly of God" or "of El." The "gods" (elohim) of verses 1 and 6 are understood as the heavenly beings who were thought to rule the nations (compare Deuteronomy 32:8 in the Septuagint and Dead Sea Scrolls), or as human rulers and judges acting in God's name. Jesus quotes verse 6 in John 10:34–36.

Chapter 83

A song. A psalm of Asaph.

1 O God, do not stay silent;
do not hold back or be quiet, O God!
2 For look, your enemies are in an uproar;
those who hate you have raised their heads.
3 Against your people they plot cunningly;
they conspire against those you shelter.
4 They say, "Come, let us wipe them out as a nation,
so that the name of Israel is remembered no more!"
5 For they plot together with one heart;
against you they make a covenant:
6 the tents of Edom and the Ishmaelites,
Moab and the Hagrites,

7 Gebal[a] and Ammon and Amalek,
Philistia with those who live in Tyre;
8 Assyria too has joined them;
they have become the strong arm[b] of the children of Lot.[c]
Selah
9 Do to them as you did to Midian,
as to Sisera and Jabin at the Wadi Kishon,[d]
10 They perished at En-dor;
they became manure for the soil.
11 Make their nobles like Oreb and Zeeb,
all their princes like Zebah and Zalmunna,
12 who said, "Let us seize for ourselves
the pastures of God."
13 O my God, make them like a spinning wheel of thistle,[e]
like straw driven by the wind.
14 As fire burns up a forest,
as a flame sets the mountains ablaze,
15 so chase them with your tempest
and terrify them with your storm.
16 Cover their faces with disgrace,
so that they may seek your name, Yahweh.
17 Let them be shamed and dismayed forever;
let them be humiliated and perish,
18 that they may know that you alone, whose name is Yahweh,
are the Most High over all the earth.

Notes

- a (83:7) Probably Byblos on the Phoenician coast, or a region south of the Dead Sea.
- b (83:8) Hebrew "arm."
- c (83:8) Moab and Ammon (Genesis 19:36–38).
- d (83:9) Compare Judges 4–8.
- e (83:13) Or "tumbleweed"; Hebrew galgal, "wheel."

Chapter 84

For the choir leader: on the Gittith. Of the sons of Korah. A psalm.

1 How lovely are your dwelling places,
Yahweh of Armies!
2 My soul yearns, even wastes away,
for the courts of Yahweh;
my heart and my flesh cry out with joy
to the living God.
3 Even the sparrow has found a home,
and the swallow a nest for herself,
where she may set down her young—
at your altars, Yahweh of Armies,
my King and my God.
4 Happy are those who live in your house,
forever singing your praise!
Selah
5 Happy is the one whose strength is in you,
in whose heart are the highways to Zion.[a]
6 As they pass through the Valley of Baca,[b]
they make it a place of springs;
the early rain also wraps it in blessings.[c]
7 They walk on from strength to strength;
every one of them is seen before God in Zion.
8 Yahweh God of Armies, hear my prayer;
give ear, O God of Jacob!
Selah
9 Look on our shield, O God;[d]
regard the face of your anointed one!
10 For one day in your courts is better
than a thousand anywhere else.[e]
I would sooner stand at the threshold of the house of my God
than make my home in the tents of wickedness.
11 For Yahweh God is a sun and shield;
Yahweh bestows grace and glory;
he does not keep back any good thing
from those who walk with integrity.

12 Yahweh of Armies,
happy is the person who trusts in you!

Notes

- a (84:5) Hebrew “the highways”; that is, the pilgrim roads to Jerusalem.
- b (84:6) Or “the valley of weeping” or “of balsam trees.”
- c (84:6) Or “pools,” with different vowels.
- d (84:9) Or “O God our shield, look.” The “shield” is the king; compare 89:18.
- e (84:10) Hebrew “than a thousand.”

Chapter 85

For the choir leader. Of the sons of Korah. A psalm.

1 Yahweh, you showed favor to your land;
you restored the fortunes[a] of Jacob.
2 You lifted the iniquity of your people;
all their sin you hid from view.
Selah
3 You gathered up all your wrath;
you turned away from your blazing anger.
4 Turn us back again, God of our salvation,
and put an end to your displeasure with us.
5 Will you be angry with us forever?
Will you stretch out your anger to every generation?
6 Will you not give us life once more,
so that your people may rejoice in you?
7 Show us your covenant love, Yahweh,
and give us your salvation.
8 Let me hear what God, Yahweh, will say,
for he will speak peace to his people, to his faithful ones;
only let them not go back to foolishness.
9 Surely his salvation is close to those who fear him,
that glory may make its home in our land.
10 Covenant love and faithfulness have met;
righteousness and peace have kissed.
11 Faithfulness sprouts up from the earth,
and righteousness gazes down from heaven.

12 Yes, Yahweh will give what is good,
and our land will give its harvest.
13 Righteousness will go ahead of him
and make his footsteps a road.[b]

Notes

- a (85:1) Or "brought back the captives."
- b (85:13) Or "and will set us on the way of his steps."

Chapter 86

A prayer of David.

1 Bend down your ear, Yahweh, and answer me,
for I am poor and in need.
2 Keep my soul, for I am faithful to you;[a]
save your servant, you who are my God,
the one who trusts in you.
3 Be gracious to me, Lord,
for to you I call all day long.
4 Bring joy to the soul of your servant,
for to you, Lord, I lift up my soul.
5 For you, Lord, are good and forgiving,
rich in covenant love to all who call to you.
6 Hear my prayer, Yahweh;
listen to my plea for grace.
7 In the day of my trouble I call to you,
for you will answer me.
8 There is none like you among the gods, Lord,
and no works are like yours.
9 All the nations you have made will come
and bow down before you, Lord,
and they will give glory to your name.
10 For you are great and do wonders;
you alone are God.
11 Teach me your way, Yahweh,
that I may walk in your truth;
make my heart single to fear your name.

12 I will thank you, Lord my God, with my whole heart,
and I will glorify your name forever.
13 For great is your covenant love toward me;
you have rescued my soul from the depths of Sheol.[b]
14 O God, insolent men have risen against me;
a gang of ruthless men seeks my life,
and they do not keep you before them.
15 But you, Lord, are a merciful and kind God,
patient and full of steadfast love and truth.[c]
16 Turn toward me and have mercy on me;
grant your strength to your servant,
and rescue the son of your handmaid.
17 Give me a token of your favor,
and my haters will see it and be ashamed,
for you, Yahweh, are the one who has aided and consoled me.

Notes

- a (86:2) Hebrew khasid, "one devoted to covenant love."
- b (86:13) The realm of the dead.
- c (86:15) Compare Exodus 34:6.

Chapter 87

Of the sons of Korah. A psalm. A song.

1 His foundation is on the holy mountains.[a]
2 Yahweh loves the gates of Zion
above all the dwellings of Jacob.
3 Glorious things are said of you,
O city of God.
Selah
4 "I will record Rahab[b] and Babylon
among those who know me;
look, Philistia and Tyre, with Cush—
'This one was born there,' they say."
5 And of Zion it will be said,
"This one and that one were born in her,"
and the Most High himself will make her secure.

6 Yahweh records as he writes down the peoples,
"This one was born there."
Selah
7 Singers and dancers alike will say,
"All my springs are in you."

Notes

- a (87:1) The Hebrew of this brief psalm is compressed and in places obscure.
- b (87:4) A poetic name for Egypt; compare 89:10; Isaiah 30:7.

Chapter 88

A song. A psalm of the sons of Korah. For the choir leader: according to Mahalath Leannoth. A Maskil of Heman the Ezrahite.

1 Yahweh, God of my salvation,
by day I cry out, and by night before you.
2 Let my prayer come into your presence;
turn your ear to my crying!
3 For my soul is sated with troubles,
and my life has drawn near to Sheol.
4 I am reckoned among those who go down to the pit;
I am like a man without strength,
5 cast loose among the dead,
like the slain who lie in the grave,
whom you remember no longer,
for they are cut off from your hand.
6 You have put me in the lowest pit,
in dark places, in the depths.
7 Your fury lies heavy on me,
and you overwhelm me with all your breakers.
Selah
8 You have taken my friends far from me;
you have made me loathsome to them.
I am shut in and cannot get out;
9 my eye wastes away because of affliction.
Every day I call to you, Yahweh;
I spread out my hands to you.

10 Will you show wonders to the dead?
Will the departed[c] stand up and praise you?
Selah
11 Is your covenant love told in the grave,
or your faithfulness in Abaddon?[d]
12 Are your wonders known in the darkness,
or your righteousness in the land of forgetting?
13 But I cry to you, Yahweh, for help;
in the morning my prayer comes before you.
14 Yahweh, why do you reject me?
Why do you keep your face hidden from me?
15 I have been afflicted and close to death since my youth;
I bear your terrors; I am helpless.[e]
16 Your burning anger has swept over me;
your terrors have destroyed me.
17 They surround me like water all day;
they close in on me together.
18 You have taken lover and companion far from me;
my closest friend is darkness.[f]

Notes

- a (88 title) Perhaps "on sickness, for affliction," or the name of a tune; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (88 title) Compare 1 Kings 4:31; 1 Chronicles 2:6; 15:19. This is the darkest of the laments; it ends without any word of hope.
- c (88:10) Hebrew rephaim, the dead in the underworld.
- d (88:11) "Destruction," a name for the place of the dead.
- e (88:15) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- f (88:18) Or "my companions are in darkness."

Chapter 89

A Maskil of Ethan the Ezrahite.

1 I will sing of the covenant love of Yahweh forever;
with my mouth I will make your faithfulness known to every generation.
2 For I said, "Covenant love is built up forever;
in the heavens you have fixed your faithfulness."

3 “I have cut a covenant with my chosen one;
I have sworn to David my servant:
4 ‘I will make your offspring secure forever
and build up your throne for all generations.’”
Selah
5 The heavens praise your wonders, Yahweh,
and your faithfulness in the gathering of the holy ones.
6 For who in the skies can be ranked with Yahweh?
Who among the sons of the gods[b] is like Yahweh,
7 a God feared in the assembly of the holy ones,
more awesome than all who stand around him?
8 Yahweh God of Armies,
who is mighty as you are, O Yah?[c]
Your faithfulness is all around you.
9 You rule the swelling of the sea;
when its waves rise, you calm them.
10 You broke Rahab[d] in pieces like a corpse;
by your mighty arm your foes were scattered.
11 The heavens are yours; the earth too is yours;
the world and everything in it, you founded them.
12 North and south—you made them;
Tabor and Hermon ring out with joy in your name.
13 Yours is an arm with might;
your hand is strong; your right hand is lifted high.
14 Righteousness and justice are the base of your throne;
covenant love and faithfulness go ahead of your face.
15 Blessed is the people that knows the shout of celebration;
Yahweh, they will walk in the light of your face.
16 In your name they rejoice all the day,
and in your righteousness they are lifted up.
17 For you are the splendor of their might,
and through your goodwill our horn[e] is exalted.
18 For our shield belongs to Yahweh,
our king to the Holy One of Israel.

19 Long ago you spoke by vision to your devoted ones[f] and said,
"I have given aid to a warrior;
I have exalted a man chosen out of the people.
20 I have found David my servant;
with my holy oil I have anointed him.
21 My hand will stay with him;
my arm also will make him strong.
22 No enemy will get the better of him;
no son of wickedness will humble him.
23 I will beat down his foes in front of him
and strike those who hate him.
24 My faithfulness and my covenant love will be with him,
and in my name his horn will be lifted high.
25 I will set his hand on the sea
and his right hand on the rivers.
26 He will cry to me, 'You are my Father,
my God, and the Rock of my salvation.'
27 And I will make him the firstborn,
highest of the kings of the earth.
28 I will keep my covenant love for him forever,
and my covenant with him will stand firm.
29 I will establish his offspring for all time,
and his throne like the days of the heavens.
30 If his children forsake my instruction
and do not live by my rulings,
31 if they profane my decrees
and fail to observe my commands,
32 then I will punish their transgression with the rod
and their iniquity with blows,
33 but I will not take away my covenant love from him[g]
or prove false to my faithfulness.
34 I will not violate my covenant
or change what has gone out from my lips.

35 Once for all I have sworn by my holiness;
I will not lie to David.
36 His offspring will endure forever,
and his throne like the sun before me.
37 Like the moon it will be established forever,
a faithful witness in the sky."
Selah
38 But now you have cast off and spurned;
you are full of wrath against your anointed.
39 You have renounced the covenant with your servant;
you have dragged his crown in the dust.
40 You have breached every one of his walls;
you have left his fortresses in ruins.
41 Everyone passing by on the road robs him;
to his neighbors he has become an object of scorn.
42 You have lifted high the right hand of his adversaries;
you have given all his enemies cause to rejoice.
43 You have even turned back the edge of his sword
and have not held him up in battle.
44 You have ended his splendor
and hurled his throne to the ground.
45 You have cut short the days of his youth;
you have wrapped him in shame.
Selah
46 How long, Yahweh? Will you hide yourself forever?
Will your wrath keep burning like fire?
47 Remember how fleeting my life is!
For what emptiness you have created all the children of man!
48 What man can live and not see death?
Who can rescue his soul from the power of Sheol?
Selah
49 Lord, where are your covenant loves of old,
which you swore to David in your faithfulness?

50 Remember, Lord, how your servants are taunted,
how I carry in my bosom the insults of all the many peoples,
51 with which your enemies taunt, Yahweh,
with which they taunt the footsteps of your anointed.
52 Blessed be Yahweh forever!
Amen and Amen.[h]

Notes

- a (89 title) Compare 1 Kings 4:31. The psalm celebrates God's covenant with David (2 Samuel 7:8–16) and then laments its apparent collapse.
- b (89:6) Or "the heavenly beings"; Hebrew bene ʾelim.
- c (89:8) Yah is the short form of the name Yahweh.
- d (89:10) A name for the sea monster of chaos, also used of Egypt; compare 87:4; Job 26:12.
- e (89:17) So the qere; the ketiv has "you raise our horn." The horn is a picture of strength.
- f (89:19) Many Hebrew manuscripts have "your faithful one."
- g (89:33) So the Hebrew; some manuscripts and versions read "I will not remove."
- h (89:52) This doxology closes Book Three of the Psalms; compare 41:13; 72:18–19; 106:48.

Chapter 90

Book Four (Psalms 90–106)

A prayer of Moses, the man of God.

1 Lord, you have been our home[b]
in generation after generation.
2 Before the mountains were born,
before you brought forth the earth and the world,
from everlasting to everlasting you are God.
3 You return mortals to dust[c]
and say, "Go back, children of Adam!"
4 For a thousand years in your eyes
are like yesterday once it has gone by,
or like a watch in the night.[d]
5 You sweep them away; they are like a sleep,
like grass that springs up in the morning:
6 in the morning it blooms and springs up;
by evening it fades and dries out.

7 For we are spent by your anger;
by your fury we are terrified.
8 You have placed our iniquities in front of you,
our hidden sins in the light of your face.
9 For all our days slip away under your wrath;
we finish our years like a sigh.
10 Seventy years make up the days of our life,
or, given strength, eighty;[e]
yet the best of them[f] is labor and sorrow;
quickly it passes, and away we fly.
11 Who knows the power of your anger,
and your wrath, as the fear of you deserves?
12 Teach us, then, to count our days,
that we may bring home a heart of wisdom.
13 Return, Yahweh! How long?
Have pity on your servants!
14 Fill us in the morning with your covenant love,
so that we may sing for joy and be glad through all our days.
15 Give us gladness for as many days as you have afflicted us,
for as many years as we have seen evil.
16 Let your servants see what you do,
and their sons your majesty.
17 Let the kindness[g] of the Lord our God be on us,
and make the work of our hands secure for us—
yes, make the work of our hands secure!

Notes

- a (90 title) Book Four of the Psalms begins here and closes with the doxology at 106:48. This is the only psalm attributed to Moses; compare Deuteronomy 33:1. From Book Four onward the Septuagint and Vulgate number most psalms one lower than the Hebrew (see the note on Psalm 9).
- b (90:1) Or "refuge."
- c (90:3) Hebrew "to crushed matter"; compare Genesis 3:19.
- d (90:4) Compare 2 Peter 3:8. A night watch was about four hours.
- e (90:10) Hebrew "threescore years and ten, … fourscore."
- f (90:10) Or "their pride."
- g (90:17) Or "beauty."

Chapter 91

1 The one who lives in the hiding place of the Most High
will rest under the shade of the Almighty.[a]
2 I will say to Yahweh, "My refuge and my fortress,
my God, in whom I trust."
3 For he will rescue you from the trap of the bird catcher
and from the deadly plague.
4 He will shelter you under his pinions;
under his wings you will take cover;
his faithfulness is shield and wall.
5 You need not dread the horror that comes by night,
or the arrow flying by day,
6 nor the plague that stalks in the dark,
nor the destruction that ravages at noon.
7 A thousand may fall at your side,
ten thousand at your right hand,
but it will not come near you.
8 You will only look on with your eyes
and see the payment of the wicked.
9 Because you have made Yahweh your refuge,[b]
the Most High your dwelling,
10 no evil will be allowed to meet you,
no plague will approach your tent.
11 For he will give his angels orders about you,
to guard you in all your ways.
12 They will lift you up in their hands,
lest you bruise your foot on a stone.[c]
13 You will tread on lion and cobra;
you will trample the young lion and the serpent.
14 "Because he clings to me in love, I will rescue him;
I will set him on high, because he knows my name.
15 He will call on me, and I will answer him;
I will be with him in trouble;
I will rescue him and give him honor.

16 With length of days I will satisfy him
and let him see my salvation."

Notes

- a (91:1) Hebrew Shaddai. This psalm has no title; the Septuagint attributes it to David.
- b (91:9) Hebrew "You, Yahweh, are my refuge"; the second line says that the Most High has been made the dwelling place.
- c (91:12) Verses 11–12 are quoted in Matthew 4:6 and Luke 4:10–11.

Chapter 92

A psalm. A song for the Sabbath day.

1 It is good to give thanks to Yahweh,
to sing praise to your name, O Most High,
2 to declare your covenant love in the morning,
and your faithfulness through the nights,
3 on the ten-stringed instrument and the harp,
to the murmuring music of the lyre.
4 For you, Yahweh, have gladdened me by what you have done;
at the works of your hands I sing for joy.
5 How great are your works, Yahweh!
How very deep are your thoughts!
6 The senseless man does not know it,
and the fool cannot grasp this:
7 that though the wicked spring up like grass
and all evildoers blossom,
it is for their destruction forever.
8 But you, Yahweh, are on high forever.
9 For look, your enemies, Yahweh,
for look, your enemies will perish;
all evildoers will be scattered.
10 But you have raised my horn like that of the wild ox;
I am anointed with fresh oil.[a]
11 My eyes have looked on my foes;
my ears have heard the doom of the evildoers who rise against me.

12 The righteous will flourish like the palm tree
and grow tall like a cedar in Lebanon.
13 Those planted in Yahweh's house
will thrive in the courtyards of our God.
14 They still bear fruit in old age;
they stay full of sap and green,
15 to proclaim that Yahweh is upright;
he is my rock, and there is no wrong in him.[b]

Notes

- a (92:10) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- b (92:15) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant spelling.

Chapter 93

1 Yahweh reigns;[a] he is robed in majesty;
Yahweh is robed; he has girded himself with strength.
Yes, the world is set firm; it will not be shaken.
2 Your throne has been firm from of old;
you are from everlasting.
3 The floods have lifted up, Yahweh,
the floods have lifted up their voice;
the floods lift up their pounding.
4 Mightier than the thunder of many waters,
mightier than the breakers of the sea,
is Yahweh on high!
5 Your testimonies stand utterly firm;
holiness is fitting for your house,
Yahweh, for endless days.

Notes

- a (93:1) Or "Yahweh has become king." Psalms 93 and 95–99 celebrate Yahweh's kingship.

Chapter 94

1 God of vengeance, Yahweh,
God of vengeance, shine out!

2 Lift yourself up, you judge of the earth;
pay back the arrogant as they have earned!
3 How long shall the wicked, Yahweh,
how long shall the wicked exult?
4 They pour out arrogant words;
all the evildoers boast.
5 They crush your people, Yahweh,
and oppress your inheritance.
6 They kill the widow and the foreigner,
and they murder the fatherless;
7 and they say, "Yah is not looking;
Jacob's God pays no attention."
8 Pay attention, you senseless among the people!
You fools, when will you become wise?
9 The one who set the ear in place—can he not hear?
The one who fashioned the eye—can he not see?
10 The one who corrects the nations—will he not punish?
The one who instructs mankind in knowledge—
11 Yahweh knows the thoughts of man,
that they are a mere breath.[a]
12 Happy is the man whom you discipline, Yah,
and whom you teach from your law,
13 granting him quiet in evil days,
while a pit is being dug for the wicked.
14 For Yahweh will not cast off his people;
he will not abandon his inheritance;
15 for justice will turn back to what is right,
and everyone honest in heart will follow it.
16 Who will stand up on my side against those who do evil?
Who will take my part against the workers of wrong?
17 Had Yahweh not come to help me,
my soul would quickly have settled in the silent land.
18 When I said, "My foot is slipping,"
your covenant love, Yahweh, held me up.

19 When my anxious thoughts are many within me,
your comforts delight my soul.
20 Can a seat of ruin be your partner,
which frames mischief by decree?
21 They gang up on the soul of the righteous
and declare innocent blood guilty.
22 But Yahweh has become my high fortress,
and my God the rock where I take refuge.
23 He will turn back their own iniquity on them
and wipe them out for their evil;
Yahweh our God will wipe them out.

Notes

- a (94:11) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 3:20.

Chapter 95

1 Come, let us sing for joy to Yahweh;
let us shout aloud to the Rock of our salvation!
2 Let us come before his face with thanksgiving;
let us shout to him with songs of praise!
3 For Yahweh is a great God,
and a great King above all gods.
4 The deep places of the earth lie in his hand;
the heights of the hills belong to him too.
5 The sea is his, for he made it,
and his hands formed the dry land.
6 Come, let us worship and bow low;
let us bend the knee before Yahweh, our Maker!
7 For he is our God,
and we are the people of his pasture,
the flock under his hand.
Today, if you would listen to his voice,
8 do not make your hearts stubborn as at Meribah,[a]
as that day at Massah[b] in the desert,
9 where your ancestors tested me
and put me on trial, though they had seen what I did.

10 For forty years I loathed that generation
and said, “They are a people whose hearts go astray,
and they have not known my ways.”
11 So I swore in my anger,
“They shall not enter my rest.”

Notes

- a (95:8) “Quarreling.”
- b (95:8) “Testing.” Compare Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 20:1–13. Verses 7–11 are quoted in Hebrews 3:7–11 and 4:3–7.

Chapter 96

1 Sing to Yahweh a new song;[a]
sing to Yahweh, all the earth!
2 Sing to Yahweh; bless his name;
announce his salvation from day to day.
3 Tell of his glory among the nations,
his wonders among all the peoples.
4 For great is Yahweh, and highly to be praised;
he is to be feared above all gods.
5 For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols,[b]
but Yahweh made the heavens.
6 Splendor and majesty are in front of him;
strength and beauty are in his sanctuary.
7 Give to Yahweh, families of the peoples,
give to Yahweh glory and strength!
8 Give to Yahweh the glory his name deserves;
bring an offering and come into his courts!
9 Bow down to Yahweh in the splendor of holiness;[c]
tremble before him, all the earth!
10 Say among the nations, “Yahweh reigns!
Yes, the world is set firm; it will not be shaken;
he will judge the peoples with fairness.”
11 Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice;
let the sea thunder, and all that fills it;

12 let the fields exult, and everything in them!
Then all the trees of the forest will sing for joy
13 before Yahweh, for he comes,
for he comes to judge the earth.
He will judge the world in righteousness,
and the peoples in his faithfulness.

Notes

- a (96:1) Compare 1 Chronicles 16:23–33, which contains most of this psalm.
- b (96:5) Hebrew ʾelilim, "nothings," a wordplay on ʾelohim, "gods."
- c (96:9) Or "in holy attire."

Chapter 97

1 Yahweh reigns! Let the earth rejoice;
let the many coastlands be glad!
2 Clouds and thick darkness are around him;
righteousness and justice are the base of his throne.
3 Fire goes before him
and burns up his foes on every side.
4 His lightnings light up the world;
the earth sees and trembles.
5 The mountains melt like wax before Yahweh,
before the Lord of all the earth.
6 The heavens declare his righteousness,
and all the peoples see his glory.
7 Let all who serve carved images be put to shame,
who boast in worthless idols;
bow down to him, all you gods![a]
8 Zion has heard and rejoiced;
the daughters of Judah are glad
because of your judgments, Yahweh.
9 For you, Yahweh, are Most High over all the earth;
you are exalted far above all gods.
10 You who love Yahweh, hate evil!
He guards the lives of his faithful ones;
he rescues them from the hand of the wicked.

11 Light has been sown[b] for the righteous one,
and gladness for those whose hearts are upright.
12 Rejoice in Yahweh, you righteous,
and give thanks to his holy name![c]

Notes

- a (97:7) The Septuagint has "all his angels"; compare Hebrews 1:6.
- b (97:11) So the Hebrew; one Hebrew manuscript and the ancient versions have "Light dawns."
- c (97:12) Hebrew "to the remembrance of his holiness."

Chapter 98

A psalm.

1 Sing to Yahweh a new song,
for he has done wonders!
His right hand and his holy arm
have won the victory for him.
2 Yahweh has made his salvation known;
before the eyes of the nations he has unveiled his righteousness.
3 He has remembered his covenant love and his faithfulness
toward the house of Israel.
All the ends of the earth have witnessed
the saving work of our God.
4 Raise a shout to Yahweh, all the earth!
Burst out in joyful song and make music!
5 Play to Yahweh on the lyre,
on the lyre, with the voice of melody!
6 With trumpets and the sound of the shofar,
raise a shout before the King, Yahweh!
7 Let the sea thunder, and everything in it,
the world, and those who live there!
8 Let the rivers clap their hands;
let the mountains sing out together for joy
9 before Yahweh, for he comes to judge the earth.
He will judge the world in righteousness
and the peoples with equity.

Chapter 99

1 Yahweh is king; let the nations shake!
  He is seated between the cherubim; let the earth tremble!
2 Great is Yahweh in Zion;
  high is he above all the peoples.
3 Let them praise your name, great and awesome.
  Holy is he![a]
4 Mighty is the King who loves justice.[b]
  You have established fairness;
  you have done justice and righteousness in Jacob.
5 Exalt Yahweh our God
  and bow down at his footstool!
  Holy is he!
6 Moses and Aaron were among his priests,
  and Samuel among those who called on his name.
  They called to Yahweh, and he answered them.
7 He spoke to them from the pillar of cloud;
  they obeyed his laws and the rule he gave them.
8 Yahweh our God, you answered them;
  you were a God who forgave them,
  yet one who punished their misdeeds.
9 Exalt Yahweh our God,
  and bow down at his holy mountain,
  for Yahweh our God is holy!

Notes

- a (99:3) The refrain "Holy is he" recurs in verses 5 and 9.
- b (99:4) The Hebrew of this line is difficult.

Chapter 100

A psalm for giving thanks.

1 Shout to Yahweh, all the earth!
2 Serve Yahweh with gladness!
  Come into his presence with joyful singing!

3 Know that Yahweh is God!
He made us, and we are his;[b]
we are his people, the sheep he pastures.
4 Enter his gates with thanksgiving,
and his courts with praise!
Thank him; bless his name!
5 For Yahweh is good;
his covenant love lasts forever,
and his faithfulness through all generations.

Notes

- a (100 title) Or "for the thank offering."
- b (100:3) So the qere (lo, "his"); the ketiv (lo', "not") reads "and not we ourselves."

Chapter 101

Of David. A psalm.

1 I will sing of covenant love and justice;
to you, Yahweh, I will make music.
2 I will consider carefully the path that is blameless—
when will you visit me?
In my own house I will live
with a heart of integrity.
3 I will not set before my eyes
anything worthless.
I hate the deeds of those who turn aside;
they will not cling to me.
4 A crooked heart will be far from me;
I will have nothing to do with evil.
5 Whoever slanders his neighbor in secret,
I will silence him.[a]
Whoever has haughty eyes and a swollen heart,
I will not put up with him.
6 My eyes will rest on the faithful in the land,
that they may dwell beside me;
the one whose path is blameless
will minister to me.

7 No one who practices deceit
will live inside my house;
no one who tells lies
will stand firm before my eyes.
8 Each morning I will silence
the wicked of this land,
uprooting all evildoers
from the city of Yahweh.

Notes

- a (101:5) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant spelling of the same verb.

Chapter 102

A prayer of one who is afflicted, when he grows faint and pours out his lament before Yahweh.

1 Yahweh, hear my prayer;
let my cry for help reach you!
2 Do not turn your face away from me
in my day of trouble!
Bend your ear to me;
when I call, be quick to answer!
3 For my days vanish like smoke,
and my bones glow like a furnace.
4 My heart is struck down and dried up like grass;
I even forget to eat my bread.
5 Because of my loud groaning
my bones stick to my flesh.
6 I am like a desert owl,[a]
like a little owl among the ruins.
7 I stay awake;
I am like a solitary bird on a rooftop.
8 My enemies insult me the whole day;
those who rage at me swear oaths by my name.
9 For I eat ashes as my bread
and mix tears into my drink,

10 because of your fury and your anger;
for you have lifted me up and thrown me away.
11 My days are like an evening shadow stretching out;
like grass I dry up.
12 But you, Yahweh, are enthroned forever;
your renown lasts through all generations.
13 You will rise and have compassion on Zion,
for it is time to show her favor;
the appointed time has come.
14 For your servants hold her stones dear
and pity her dust.
15 Nations will fear the name of Yahweh,
and all the kings of the earth your glory.
16 For Yahweh has built up Zion;
he has been seen in his glory.
17 He will turn to the prayer of the destitute
and will not despise their plea.
18 Let this be written down for a later generation,
so that a people yet to be created may praise Yah:
19 that he gazed down from his sanctuary on high;
Yahweh looked from heaven to the earth,
20 to hear the groans of prisoners,
to set free those condemned to die,
21 so that the name of Yahweh may be declared in Zion,
and his praise in Jerusalem,
22 when peoples gather together,
and kingdoms, to serve Yahweh.
23 He has humbled my strength on the road;[b]
he has shortened my days.
24 I say, "My God, do not take me away
in the middle of my days—
you whose years go on through all generations!
25 Long ago you founded the earth,
and the heavens are the work of your hands.[c]

[26] They will be destroyed, but you will last;
they will all wear out like a coat.
You will swap them like clothes,
and they will be gone;
[27] but you are he who is,
and your years have no end.
[28] The children of your servants will dwell secure,
and their offspring will be established before you."

Notes

- a (102:6) The identification of these birds is uncertain.
- b (102:23) So the qere; the ketiv reads "his strength."
- c (102:25) Verses 25–27 are quoted in Hebrews 1:10–12.

Chapter 103

Of David.

[1] Bless Yahweh, my soul,
and all that is within me, bless his holy name!
[2] Bless Yahweh, my soul,
and forget none of his kindnesses—
[3] who pardons every one of your iniquities,
who cures every one of your sicknesses,
[4] who buys back your life from the pit,
who sets a crown on you of covenant love and compassion,
[5] who satisfies your years[a] with good,
so that your youth is renewed like the eagle's.
[6] Yahweh does righteous deeds
and justice for all the oppressed.
[7] He made his ways known to Moses,
his deeds to the people of Israel.
[8] Yahweh is compassionate and gracious,
slow to anger and rich in covenant love.[b]
[9] He will not always accuse,
nor will he hold on to his anger forever.
[10] He has not treated us as our sins deserve,
nor repaid us according to our iniquities.

11 For as high as the heavens are above the earth,
so mighty is his covenant love toward those who fear him;
12 as far as the sunrise is from the sunset,
so far has he removed our transgressions from us.
13 As a father has compassion on his children,
so Yahweh has compassion on those who fear him.
14 For he knows what we are made of;
he keeps in mind that we are dust.
15 Man—his days are like the grass;
like a wildflower, so he blossoms;
16 when the wind passes over it, it is gone,
and its place no longer recognizes it.
17 But the covenant love of Yahweh is from everlasting to everlasting
on those who fear him,
and his righteousness to children's children,
18 for those who hold to his covenant
and keep his precepts in mind to do them.
19 Yahweh has set up his throne in the heavens,
and his kingdom rules over all.
20 Bless Yahweh, you his angels,
mighty in strength, who carry out his word,
obeying the voice of his word!
21 Bless Yahweh, all his hosts,
his ministers who carry out his desire!
22 Bless Yahweh, all his works,
in every place of his dominion!
Bless Yahweh, my soul!

Notes

- a (103:5) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; traditionally "your mouth."
- b (103:8) Compare Exodus 34:6.

Chapter 104

1 Bless Yahweh, my soul!
Yahweh my God, you are very great!
You are clothed with splendor and majesty,

2 wrapping yourself in light as in a robe,
stretching out the heavens like a tent curtain.
3 He sets the frame of his upstairs rooms on the waters;
he takes the clouds as his chariot;
he travels on the wings of the wind;
4 he makes the winds his messengers,
flames of fire his servants.[a]
5 He fixed the earth on its bases,
so that it will not totter, forever and ever.
6 You covered it with the deep as with a garment;
the waters stood above the mountains.
7 They fled from your rebuke;
they ran in haste at your thunder's voice.
8 The mountains rose, the valleys sank[b]
to the place you had appointed for them.
9 You set a boundary they may not cross,
so that they never again cover the earth.
10 You make springs gush out in the valleys;
they flow between the hills;
11 they give drink to every animal of the field;
the wild donkeys quench their thirst.
12 Beside them the birds of the heavens nest;
they sing among the branches.
13 From your upper rooms you water the mountains;
the earth is satisfied with the fruit of your work.
14 You cause grass to sprout for the livestock
and plants for the labor of mankind,
so that bread comes out of the earth,
15 and wine that gladdens the heart of man,
oil to make his face shine,
and bread that strengthens the heart of man.
16 The trees of Yahweh drink their fill,
the cedars of Lebanon that he planted,

17 There the birds make their nests;
the stork lives in the junipers.
18 The high mountains are for the wild goats;
the rocks are a refuge for the rock badgers.[c]
19 He made the moon for the set times;[d]
the sun knows its hour for going down.
20 You bring darkness, and it is night,
when all the beasts of the forest prowl.
21 Young lions roar after prey
and ask God for their food.
22 The sun comes up, and they slip away
to lie down in their lairs.
23 Man goes out to his work
and to his labor until evening.
24 How many are your works, Yahweh!
In wisdom you have made them all;
the earth is full of your creatures.
25 There is the sea, great and wide,
teeming with creatures beyond number,
living things both small and great.
26 There ships go back and forth,
and Leviathan, whom you shaped to frolic there.[e]
27 All of them look to you
to give them their food in its season.
28 You give to them, and they gather;
you open your hand, and they are filled with good.
29 When you hide your face, they panic;
when you remove their breath, they die
and go back to dust.
30 When you send out your Spirit,[f] they are created,
and you renew the face of the ground.
31 May the glory of Yahweh last forever;
may Yahweh rejoice in his works,

32 He looks on the earth, and it quakes;
he touches the mountains, and smoke rises!
33 All my life I will sing to Yahweh;
I will sing praise to my God while I live.
34 May my meditation be pleasing to him;
as for me, I rejoice in Yahweh.
35 Let sinners vanish from the earth,
and let the wicked be no more!
Bless Yahweh, my soul!
Hallelujah![g]

Notes

- a (104:4) Or "he makes his angels winds." Quoted in Hebrews 1:7.
- b (104:8) Or "They went up the mountains and went down into the valleys."
- c (104:18) Hebrew shephanim, the rock hyrax.
- d (104:19) Or "the appointed festivals."
- e (104:26) Or "to play with." Compare Job 41:5.
- f (104:30) Or "your breath."
- g (104:35) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" Yah is a short form of the name Yahweh. This is the first occurrence of the word in the Bible; it recurs in Psalms 105–106, 111–113, 115–117, 135, and 146–150, and in Revelation 19:1–6. CJT keeps the familiar transliteration "Hallelujah."

Chapter 105

1 Give thanks to Yahweh; call on his name;[a]
make his deeds known among the peoples!
2 Sing to him, make music to him;
ponder all his wonders!
3 Take pride in his holy name;
may the hearts that seek Yahweh rejoice!
4 Search for Yahweh and his strength;
seek his face always!
5 Remember the wonders he has worked,
his signs, and the judgments he has spoken,
6 you offspring of Abraham, his servant,
you children of Jacob, his chosen ones!

7 He is Yahweh our God;
his judgments are in all the earth.
8 He remembers his covenant forever,
the word he decreed for a thousand generations,
9 the covenant he made with Abraham,
his sworn promise to Isaac,
10 He made it firm for Jacob as an ordinance,
an everlasting covenant for Israel,
11 declaring, “The land of Canaan I give to you,
your allotted inheritance.”
12 When they were few in number,
a mere handful, and foreigners in it,
13 wandering from nation to nation,
from one kingdom to another people,
14 he let no one oppress them;
he rebuked kings on their account:
15 “Do not touch my anointed ones,
and do my prophets no harm!”
16 He called down a famine over the country
and snapped every supply of bread.[b]
17 Ahead of them he had sent a man:
Joseph, sold into slavery.
18 They hurt his feet with shackles;
his neck[c] was put in iron,
19 until the time that his word came true;
the word of Yahweh tested him.
20 The king gave the order to loose him;
the one who ruled the peoples released him.
21 He made him lord over his household
and ruler over all his possessions,
22 to bind his princes at his will
and to teach his elders wisdom.
23 Israel then entered Egypt;
Jacob stayed as an alien in Ham’s land.[d]

24 And God made his people very fruitful
and made them stronger than their foes.
25 He turned their hearts to hate his people,
to deal craftily with his servants.
26 He sent Moses, his servant,
and Aaron, whom he had chosen.
27 They performed his signs among them,[e]
and wonders in the land of Ham.
28 He sent darkness and made it dark;
did they not rebel against his words?[f]
29 He turned their waters into blood
and made their fish die.
30 Their land swarmed with frogs,
even in the rooms of their kings.
31 He spoke, and swarms of flies came,
and gnats throughout their territory.
32 He gave them hail in place of rain,
and flashes of fire throughout their land.
33 He battered their vines and their fig trees
and splintered the trees throughout their borders.
34 He spoke, and the locusts came,
young locusts without number,
35 which devoured all the vegetation in their land
and ate up the fruit of their ground.
36 He struck down every firstborn in their land,
the first fruits of all their vigor.
37 Then he brought Israel out with silver and gold,
and among his tribes no one stumbled.
38 Egypt was glad when they left,
for dread of Israel had fallen on them.
39 He stretched a cloud over them for a screen
and fire to give light by night.
40 They made a request, and he sent quail,
and filled them with heaven's bread.

41 He opened the rock, and water gushed out;
it ran through the dry land like a river.
42 For he remembered his holy word
to Abraham, his servant.
43 He led his people out rejoicing,
his chosen with songs of joy.
44 He gave them the lands of the nations,
and they took possession of what the peoples had toiled for,
45 so that they might keep his statutes
and observe his laws.
Hallelujah![g]

Notes

- a (105:1) Verses 1–15 appear also in 1 Chronicles 16:8–22.
- b (105:16) That is, the food supply.
- c (105:18) Hebrew nephesh, "his soul" or "his throat." So the qere; the ketiv has "his foot" in the previous line.
- d (105:23) A poetic name for Egypt; compare Genesis 10:6.
- e (105:27) Hebrew "They set among them the words of his signs."
- f (105:28) So the qere (and the Septuagint and Syriac omit "not": "they rebelled against his words"). The ketiv reads "his word." The sense of the line is debated.
- g (105:45) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" See the note on 104:35.

Chapter 106

1 Hallelujah![a]
Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good,
for his covenant love lasts forever!
2 Who can tell of the mighty deeds of Yahweh
or make all his praise heard?
3 Happy are those who keep justice,
who do righteousness at all times!
4 Remember me, Yahweh, when you show favor to your people;
visit me with your salvation,
5 that I may see the prosperity of your chosen ones,
that I may rejoice in the gladness of your nation,
that I may boast along with your inheritance.

6 We have sinned, as our fathers did;
we have done wrong; we have acted wickedly.
7 Our fathers in Egypt
did not grasp your wonders;
they did not remember your abundant covenant love,
but rebelled at the sea, at the Red Sea.[b]
8 Yet he saved them for the sake of his name,
to make his might known.
9 He rebuked the Red Sea, and it became dry;
he guided them through the depths as if through open country.
10 He rescued them from those who hated them
and redeemed them from their enemy's grip.
11 The waters closed over their foes;
not a single one survived.
12 Then they believed his words;
they sang his praise.
13 How soon they forgot what he had done!
They would not wait for his plan.
14 In the wilderness they were seized with greed
and tested God in the barren land.
15 So he granted their request,
yet he sent a wasting into their souls.
16 In the camp they grew jealous of Moses
and of Aaron, the holy one of Yahweh.
17 The earth opened and swallowed Dathan
and covered the company of Abiram.
18 Fire blazed out among their company;
flame burned up the wicked.
19 They made a calf at Horeb
and bowed down to a cast image.
20 They traded away their Glory[c]
for the likeness of a grass-eating bull.
21 They forgot God, their Savior,
who had done great things in Egypt,

22 wondrous works in the land of Ham,
awesome deeds at the Red Sea.
23 So he said he would destroy them—
had not Moses, his chosen one,
stood in the breach before him,
to turn his wrath away from destroying them.
24 Then they scorned the desirable land;
they put no faith in his promise.
25 They muttered in their tents
and would not heed Yahweh's voice.
26 So he lifted his hand to them in an oath
to bring them down in the wilderness,
27 and make their offspring fall among the nations,
and scatter them throughout the lands.
28 They attached themselves to Baal of Peor
and ate offerings made to the dead.[d]
29 Their deeds provoked him to anger,
and plague burst out on them.
30 But Phinehas rose and stepped in to judge,
and the plague was held back.
31 It was credited to him as righteousness
for all generations, forever.
32 They angered him at the waters of Meribah,
and it went badly for Moses because of them,
33 because they made his spirit bitter,
and rash words came from his lips.
34 They did not destroy the peoples,
as Yahweh had commanded them,
35 but they intermingled with the nations
and adopted their ways.
36 They served their idols,
which became a snare to them.
37 They sacrificed their sons
and their daughters to demons.

38 They poured out innocent blood,
the blood of their sons and daughters,
whom they sacrificed to the idols of Canaan,
and the land was defiled with bloodshed.
39 So they became unclean by their deeds
and prostituted themselves in their practices.
40 Then the anger of Yahweh burned against his people,
and he loathed his own inheritance.
41 He gave them into the hand of the nations,
and those who hated them ruled over them.
42 Their enemies oppressed them,
and they were humbled under their power.
43 Many times he rescued them,
but they were rebellious in their plans
and sank low through their iniquity.
44 Yet he looked on their distress
when he heard their cry.
45 He called to mind his covenant for their sake
and had a change of heart in his abundant covenant love.[e]
46 He made all their captors
feel pity for them.
47 Save us, Yahweh our God!
Gather us out of the nations
to thank your holy name
and to take pride in praising you.
48 Blessed be Yahweh, the God of Israel,
from everlasting to everlasting!
And let all the people say, "Amen!"
Hallelujah![f]

Notes

- a (106:1) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" See the note on 104:35. Verses 1 and 47–48 appear also in 1 Chronicles 16:34–36.
- b (106:7) Hebrew Yam Suph, "Sea of Reeds," here and in verses 9 and 22.
- c (106:20) That is, God. An ancient scribal tradition records that the original reading was "my glory."

- d (106:28) Or “to lifeless gods.” Compare Numbers 25:1–9.
- e (106:45) So the qere (plural, “his many acts of covenant love”); the ketiv is singular.
- f (106:48) This doxology closes Book Four of the Psalms; compare 41:13, 72:18–19, and 89:52. Hebrew hallelu-yah, “Praise Yah!”

Chapter 107

Book Five (Psalms 107–150)

1 Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good,
for his covenant love lasts forever![a]
2 Let the redeemed of Yahweh say so,
those he redeemed from the grip of the foe
3 and gathered in from the lands,
from east and from west,
from north and from the sea.[b]
4 Some wandered in the wilderness, in the desert wastes;
they found no road to a city where they could settle.
5 Hungry and thirsty,
their souls grew faint within them.
6 Then they cried out to Yahweh in their trouble,
and he rescued them from their distress.
7 He led them by a straight path
until they reached a city to live in.
8 Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love,
for his wonders toward the children of Adam![c]
9 For he satisfies the thirsty soul,
and the hungry soul he fills with good things.
10 Some sat in darkness and deep gloom,[d]
prisoners in misery and chains,
11 because they had rebelled against God’s words
and scorned the plan of the Most High.
12 So he humbled their hearts with hard labor;
they stumbled, and no one helped.
13 Then they cried out to Yahweh in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.

14 He brought them out of darkness and deep gloom
and tore their chains apart.
15 Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love,
for his wonders toward the children of Adam!
16 For he has broken down gates of bronze
and hacked through iron bars.
17 Some were fools in their rebellious ways
and suffered for their iniquities;
18 their appetite turned against all food,
and they drew near to death's gates.
19 Then they cried out to Yahweh in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.
20 He sent out his word and healed them
and rescued them from their pits.
21 Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love,
for his wonders toward the children of Adam!
22 Let them bring thank offerings in sacrifice
and recount his works with shouts of joy!
23 Some went down to the sea in ships,
doing their trade on the mighty waters;
24 they saw the works of Yahweh,
his wonders in the deep.
25 For he spoke and raised up a stormy wind,
which lifted high the waves.
26 They rose to the sky; they plunged to the depths;
their courage melted in their peril.
27 They reeled and lurched like drunkards,
and all their skill was swallowed up.
28 Then they cried out to Yahweh in their trouble,
and he brought them out of their distress.
29 He made the gale grow calm,
and the sea's waves[e] fell silent.
30 They were glad when it grew quiet,
and he guided them to the harbor they longed for.

31 Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love,
for his wonders toward the children of Adam!
32 Let them exalt him in the assembly of the people
and praise him in the council of the elders!
33 He turns rivers into desert,
springs of water into thirsty ground,
34 a fruitful land into a salt flat,
because of the evil of those who live there.
35 He turns desert into pools of water,
parched land into springs.
36 There he settles the hungry,
and they build a city to live in;
37 they sow fields and plant vineyards
and gather a fruitful harvest.
38 He blesses them so that they increase greatly,
and he keeps their livestock from growing few.
39 When they are diminished and brought low
through oppression, trouble, and sorrow,
40 he heaps scorn on princes
and sends them wandering in pathless wastes;[f]
41 but he raises the poor up from misery
and multiplies their clans like sheep.
42 The upright look on and rejoice,
and every wrongdoer's mouth is stopped.
43 Whoever is wise, let him heed these things,
and let them consider the covenant love of Yahweh.

Notes

- a (107:1) Book Five of the Psalms begins here and runs to the closing doxology of Psalm 150. It contains the Songs of Ascents (120–134), the Hallel psalms (113–118), the acrostic Psalm 119, and the closing Hallelujah psalms (146–150).
- b (107:3) That is, from the south; the Hebrew has "from the sea."
- c (107:8) This refrain recurs in verses 15, 21, and 31.
- d (107:10) Or "the shadow of death," also in verse 14.
- e (107:29) Hebrew "their waves."
- f (107:40) Compare Job 12:21, 24.

Chapter 108

A song. A psalm of David.

1 My heart is steadfast, God;
I will sing and make music with all my being.[b]
2 Awake, harp and lyre!
I will awaken the dawn.
3 I will thank you among the peoples, Yahweh;
I will make music to you among the nations.
4 For your covenant love is great above the heavens,
and your faithfulness reaches to the clouds.
5 Be exalted above the heavens, God,
and let your glory be over all the earth!
6 That those you love may be rescued,
save with your right hand and answer me!
7 God has spoken in his holiness:[c]
"I will exult; I will divide up Shechem
and measure out the valley of Succoth.
8 Gilead is mine; Manasseh is mine;
Ephraim is the helmet on my head;
Judah is my scepter.
9 Moab is my washbasin;
on Edom I throw my sandal;
over Philistia I shout in triumph."
10 Who will lead me into the walled city?
Who will guide me as far as Edom?
11 Have you not rejected us, God?
You do not go out, God, with our armies.
12 Help us against the enemy,
for human help is useless.
13 With God we will act with valor,
and he will tread our enemies underfoot.

Notes

- a (108 title) This psalm combines 57:7–11 (verses 1–5) and 60:5–12 (verses 6–13), with small differences.
- b (108:1) Hebrew "even my glory."

- c (108:7) Or “in his sanctuary.”

Chapter 109

To the director. Of David. A psalm.

1 God whom I praise, do not keep silent!
2 For wicked and deceitful mouths
have opened against me;
they have spoken to me with lying tongues.
3 With words of hate they hem me in
and fight me for no reason.
4 My love they answer with accusation,
while I keep praying.[a]
5 They repay me evil for good,
and hatred for my love.
6 “Set a wicked man in authority over him;
let an accuser[b] take his place at his right side.
7 When he is tried, let him come out guilty;
let his prayer be counted as sin.
8 Let his days be few;
let another take his position.[c]
9 Let his children be fatherless
and his wife a widow.
10 Let his children wander and beg,
searching for food far from their ruined homes.[d]
11 Let the creditor seize all he has;
let strangers plunder the fruit of his toil.
12 Let no one extend covenant love to him,
nor anyone pity his fatherless children.
13 Let his descendants be cut off;
in the next generation let their name be wiped out.
14 Let the iniquity of his fathers be remembered before Yahweh,
and let the sin of his mother not be wiped out.
15 Let them be before Yahweh continually,
that he may cut off their memory from the earth,

16 since he never thought to show covenant love,
but chased down the poor and the needy
and the crushed in heart, to kill them.
17 He loved cursing—let it fall on him!
Blessing gave him no pleasure—let it stay far from him!
18 He dressed himself in cursing as in a robe;
may it enter his body like water,
and his bones like oil!
19 Let it wrap him like his cloak,
like the sash he ties on day after day!”
20 May this be the reward of my accusers from Yahweh,
of those who speak evil against my life!
21 But you, Yahweh, my Lord,
deal with me for the sake of your name;
because your steadfast love is good, deliver me!
22 For I am poor and needy,
and my heart is pierced within me.
23 Like an evening shadow I am slipping away;
I am brushed off like a locust.
24 Fasting has made my knees weak;
my flesh has wasted away, lean and bare.
25 I have become an object of scorn to them;
when they see me, they shake their heads.
26 Help me, Yahweh my God!
Save me according to your covenant love!
27 Let them know that your hand is in this;
you, Yahweh, have done it!
28 Let them curse, but you will bless!
They rose up, but they will be put to shame,
and your servant will be glad.
29 Let my accusers be clothed with disgrace;
let them wear their shame like a cloak!
30 With my mouth I will give great thanks to Yahweh;
in the midst of the crowd I will praise him.

31 For he stands at the right hand of the needy,
to save him from those who would condemn his soul.

Notes

- a (109:4) Hebrew "but I—prayer."
- b (109:6) Hebrew satan. Many interpreters take verses 6–19 as the curses spoken by the psalmist's enemies against him (note "they say" implied in verse 6 and "my accusers" in verse 20); others take them as the psalmist's own words.
- c (109:8) Quoted in Acts 1:20.
- d (109:10) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "let them be driven out of their ruins."

Chapter 110

Of David. A psalm.

1 The declaration of Yahweh to my lord:[a]
"Sit at my right hand,
until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet."
2 Yahweh will send out your mighty scepter from Zion:
"Rule in the midst of your enemies!"
3 Your people will volunteer
on the day you muster your forces,
in holy splendor;[b]
out of the womb of the dawn
you will have the dew of your youth.
4 Yahweh has sworn and will not change his mind:
"You are a priest forever
after the order of Melchizedek."[c]
5 The Lord is at your right side;
he will crush kings on the day he is angry.
6 He will execute judgment on the nations
and heap up the dead;
he will crush the head over a vast land.
7 From the stream beside the road he will drink,
and so he will raise his head high.

Notes

- a (110:1) Hebrew neʾum YHWH laʾdoni. The first is the divine name Yahweh; the second is ʾadoni, "my lord, my master," a title of honor used of kings and superiors

(not the divine title ʾAdonai). Traditional English Bibles print "The LORD said unto my Lord," hiding the difference. Jesus cites this verse to show that the Messiah is more than David's son (Matthew 22:41–45; Mark 12:35–37; Luke 20:41–44); see also Acts 2:34–35, 1 Corinthians 15:25, and Hebrews 1:13. Psalm 110 is the Old Testament passage most often quoted or alluded to in the New Testament.

- b (110:3) So many Hebrew manuscripts; others read "on the holy mountains." The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- c (110:4) Or "on account of Melchizedek." Compare Genesis 14:18–20; quoted in Hebrews 5:6, 6:20, and 7:17, 21.

Chapter 111

1 Hallelujah![a]
I will give thanks to Yahweh with my whole heart,
in the circle of the upright and in the assembly.
2 Great are the works of Yahweh,
studied by all who delight in them.
3 Splendid and majestic is his work,
and his righteousness stands forever.
4 He has made his wonders to be remembered;
Yahweh is gracious and compassionate.
5 He gives food to those who fear him;
he remembers his covenant forever.
6 The might of his deeds he has made known to his people,
handing them the heritage of the nations.
7 The works of his hands are faithfulness and justice;
all his precepts are trustworthy.
8 They are upheld forever and ever,
carried out in faithfulness and uprightness.
9 He sent redemption to his people;
he has ordained his covenant forever.
Holy and awesome is his name!
10 The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of wisdom;[b]
all who practice it have good insight.
His praise stands forever.

Notes

- a (111:1) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" (see 104:35). After the opening Hallelujah, Psalms 111 and 112 are matched acrostic poems: each of their twenty-two

half-lines begins with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. The other acrostics in the Psalter are 9–10, 25, 34, 37, 119, and 145.

- b (111:10) Compare Proverbs 1:7; 9:10.

Chapter 112

1 Hallelujah![a]
  Happy is the man who fears Yahweh,
  who takes great delight in his commandments!
2 His offspring will be mighty in the land;
  the generation of the upright will be blessed.
3 Wealth and riches are in his house,
  and his righteousness stands forever.
4 For the upright a light rises in the dark—
  gracious, merciful, and just.
5 It goes well with the man who is generous and lends,
  who conducts his affairs with justice.
6 For he will never be shaken;
  the righteous will be remembered forever.
7 Evil tidings hold no terror for him;
  his heart stands steady, relying on Yahweh.
8 His heart is steady; he will not fear,
  until he looks in triumph on his foes.
9 He has scattered his gifts; he has given to the poor;[b]
  his righteousness stands forever;
  his horn will be lifted high in honor.
10 The wicked sees it and is vexed;
  he gnashes his teeth and wastes away;
  what the wicked long for comes to nothing.

Notes

- a (112:1) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" Like Psalm 111, this psalm is an acrostic; it describes the righteous person in terms Psalm 111 uses of God (compare 111:3, 4 with 112:3, 4).
- b (112:9) Quoted in 2 Corinthians 9:9.

Chapter 113

1 Hallelujah![a]
Praise, you servants of Yahweh,
praise the name of Yahweh!
2 Blessed be the name of Yahweh
from now on and forevermore!
3 From where the sun rises to where it sets,
let the name of Yahweh be praised!
4 Yahweh is high above all nations,
his glory above the heavens.
5 Who is like Yahweh our God,
who is seated on high,
6 who stoops down to look
on the heavens and the earth?
7 He lifts the lowly up out of the dust
and raises the poor from the refuse pile,
8 to seat them with princes,
with the princes of his people.
9 He gives the childless woman a home,
a joyful mother of children.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (113:1) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" Psalms 113–118 form the "Egyptian Hallel," sung at the great festivals and especially at Passover, when 113–114 were sung before the meal and 115–118 after it (compare Matthew 26:30; Mark 14:26).

Chapter 114

1 When Israel came out of Egypt,
the house of Jacob from a people of foreign speech,
2 Judah became his sanctuary,
Israel his dominion.
3 The sea saw and ran away;
the Jordan drew back.[a]
4 The mountains skipped like rams,
the hills like young sheep.

5 Sea, what made you run away?
Jordan, why did you draw back?
6 Mountains, that you skip like rams?
Hills, like young sheep?
7 Earth, writhe before the presence of the Lord,
before the presence of Jacob's God,
8 who turns the rock into a pool of water,
the flint into a flowing spring.[b]

Notes

- a (114:3) Compare Exodus 14:21–22 and Joshua 3:14–17.
- b (114:8) The Septuagint, Vulgate, and some Hebrew manuscripts join Psalms 114 and 115 as one psalm (see the note on Psalm 9).

Chapter 115

1 Not to us, Yahweh, not to us,
but to your name give glory,
because of your covenant love and your faithfulness!
2 Why should the nations say,
"Where, now, is their God?"
3 Our God is in the heavens;
he does whatever he pleases.
4 Their idols are silver and gold,
made by human hands.
5 They have a mouth, yet no speech;
they have eyes, yet no sight.
6 They have ears, yet no hearing;
they have a nose, yet no sense of smell.
7 They have hands, yet no touch;
they have feet, yet they never walk;
no sound comes from their throat.
8 Their makers will be just like them,
as will everyone who relies on them.[a]
9 Israel, trust in Yahweh!
He is their help and their shield.

10 House of Aaron, trust in Yahweh!
He is their help and their shield.
11 You who fear Yahweh, trust in Yahweh!
He is their help and their shield.
12 Yahweh has remembered us; he will bless—
he will bless the house of Israel;
he will bless the house of Aaron;
13 He will bless those who fear Yahweh,
both small and great.
14 May Yahweh give you increase,
you and your children!
15 May you be blessed by Yahweh,
the Maker of heaven and earth!
16 The heavens are the heavens of Yahweh,
but the earth he has given to the children of Adam.
17 The dead do not praise Yah,
nor do any who go down into silence.
18 But we will bless Yah
from now on and forevermore.
Hallelujah![b]

Notes

- a (115:8) Verses 4–8 are closely paralleled in 135:15–18.
- b (115:18) Hebrew hallelu-yah, "Praise Yah!" (see 104:35).

Chapter 116

1 I love Yahweh, because he hears
my voice and my pleas for mercy.
2 Because he has turned his ear to me,
I will call on him as long as I live.
3 The cords of death wrapped around me;
the anguish of Sheol[a] found me;
I found distress and grief.
4 Then I called on the name of Yahweh:
"Please, Yahweh, rescue my soul!"

5 Gracious is Yahweh, and righteous;
our God is compassionate.
6 Yahweh keeps watch over the simple;
I was laid low, and he rescued me.
7 Return, my soul, to your rest,
for Yahweh has dealt generously with you.
8 For you have rescued my soul from death,
my eyes from tears,
my feet from stumbling.
9 I will walk before Yahweh
in the land of the living.
10 I believed, even when I said,[b]
"I am greatly afflicted";
11 In my panic I said,
"Every human being is a liar."
12 What shall I give back to Yahweh
for all his benefits to me?
13 I will lift up the cup of salvation
and call on the name of Yahweh.
14 I will fulfill my vows to Yahweh
in the presence of all his people.
15 Precious in the eyes of Yahweh
is the death of his faithful ones.
16 Yahweh, truly I am your servant;
I am your servant, the son of your maidservant.
You have loosed my bonds.
17 To you I will bring a thank offering in sacrifice
and invoke the name of Yahweh.
18 I will fulfill my vows to Yahweh
in the presence of all his people,
19 in the courts of the house of Yahweh,
in your midst, Jerusalem.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (116:3) The realm of the dead.
- b (116:10) Or "I believed, therefore I spoke." The Septuagint begins a new psalm here (its Psalm 115); quoted in 2 Corinthians 4:13.

Chapter 117

1 Praise Yahweh, all you nations!
Extol him, all you peoples![a]
2 For his covenant love toward us is mighty,
and the faithfulness of Yahweh endures forever.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (117:1) The shortest psalm and the shortest chapter in the Bible. Quoted in Romans 15:11.

Chapter 118

1 Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good;
his covenant love lasts forever!
2 Let Israel say,
"His covenant love lasts forever."
3 Let the house of Aaron say,
"His covenant love lasts forever."
4 Let those who fear Yahweh say,
"His covenant love lasts forever."
5 Out of my distress I called on Yah;
Yah answered me and set me in a wide place.[a]
6 Yahweh is for me; I will not fear.
What can man do to me?[b]
7 Yahweh is for me as my helper;
I will look in triumph on those who hate me.
8 It is better to take refuge in Yahweh
than to trust in man.
9 It is better to take refuge in Yahweh
than to trust in princes.
10 All the nations surrounded me;
in Yahweh's name I destroyed them!

11 They surrounded me, yes, surrounded me;
in the name of Yahweh I cut them off!
12 They surrounded me like bees;
they were extinguished like a fire of thorns;
in the name of Yahweh I cut them off!
13 I was thrust at hard, to make me fall,[c]
but Yahweh came to my help.
14 Yah is my strength and my song,
and he has become my salvation.[d]
15 A sound of glad shouts and salvation
is in the tents of the righteous:
"The right hand of Yahweh does mighty things!
16 The right hand of Yahweh is lifted high;
the right hand of Yahweh does mighty things!"
17 I will not die, but I will live
and tell of the works of Yah.
18 Yah has disciplined me severely,
but he has not handed me over to death.
19 Open for me the gates of righteousness;
I will go in through them and thank Yah.
20 This is the gate of Yahweh;
the righteous will go in through it.
21 I thank you that you answered me
and have become my salvation.
22 The stone that the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone.[e]
23 This has come from Yahweh;
it is wonderful in our eyes.
24 This is the day that Yahweh has made;
let us rejoice and be glad in it.
25 Please, Yahweh, save us![f]
Please, Yahweh, give us success!
26 Blessed is he who comes in the name of Yahweh![g]
We bless you from the house of Yahweh.

27 Yahweh is God,
and he has given us light.
Bind the festal sacrifice with cords,
up to the horns of the altar![h]
28 You are my God, and I will thank you;
my God, I will exalt you.
29 Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good;
his covenant love lasts forever!

Notes

- a (118:5) Hebrew merkhav-yah, "a broad place of Yah."
- b (118:6) Quoted in Hebrews 13:6.
- c (118:13) Hebrew "You pushed me hard"; the Septuagint and Syriac read "I was pushed."
- d (118:14) Quoted from Exodus 15:2; compare Isaiah 12:2.
- e (118:22) Hebrew "the head of the corner." Verses 22–23 are quoted in the New Testament: in Matthew 21:42, in Mark 12:10–11, in Luke 20:17, in Acts 4:11 and in 1 Peter 2:7.
- f (118:25) Hebrew hoshiʿah na, the source of the word "Hosanna" (Matthew 21:9; Mark 11:9–10; John 12:13).
- g (118:26) Quoted in Matthew 21:9; 23:39; Mark 11:9; Luke 13:35; 19:38; John 12:13.
- h (118:27) The meaning of this line is uncertain.

Chapter 119

א Aleph

1 Happy are the people of blameless conduct,[a]
who live by the instruction of Yahweh!
2 Happy are they who guard his testimonies,
who search for him with a whole heart,
3 who never practice wrongdoing,
but keep walking in his ways!
4 You have laid down your precepts
to be kept with care.
5 Oh, that my ways were steady
in keeping your statutes!
6 Then I would not be put to shame,
when I fix my eyes on all your commandments.

7 With uprightness of heart I will praise you
while I learn the judgments of your righteousness.
8 Your statutes I will keep;
do not abandon me completely!

ב *Beth*

9 How can a young man keep his path pure?
By guarding it according to your word.
10 With all my heart I have sought you;
do not let me stray from your commandments!
11 Within my heart I have stored up your promise,
to keep me from sinning against you.
12 Blessed are you, Yahweh;
teach me your statutes!
13 With my lips I recount
all the judgments of your mouth.
14 In the way of your testimonies I rejoice
as much as in all riches.
15 On your precepts I will reflect
and keep your paths before my eyes.
16 I will delight in your statutes;
I will not forget your word.

ג *Gimel*

17 Deal generously with your servant,
that I may live and keep your word.
18 Uncover my eyes, that I may see
wonders out of your law.
19 I am only a stranger in the land;
do not conceal your commandments from me!
20 My soul is crushed with longing
for your judgments at all times.
21 You rebuke the arrogant, the cursed,
who stray from your commandments.
22 Roll scorn and contempt off me,
for I have kept your testimonies.

23 Even if princes sit and talk against me,
your servant will meditate on your statutes.
24 Your testimonies are what I delight in;
they are the men of my counsel.

ד *Daleth*

25 My soul lies stuck in the dust;
revive me as your word has said!
26 I told you my ways, and you answered me;
teach me your statutes!
27 Help me grasp the way of your precepts,
so that I may reflect on your wondrous works.
28 My soul weeps[b] from sorrow;
raise me up according to your word!
29 Keep the way of falsehood far from me,
and graciously give me your law!
30 I have chosen the way of faithfulness;
I have set your judgments before me.
31 I cling to your testimonies, Yahweh;
do not put me to shame!
32 I will run the way of your commandments,
for you enlarge my heart.

ה *He*

33 Yahweh, instruct me in the way your statutes go,
and I will guard it to the last.[c]
34 Give me understanding, and I will keep your law
and observe it with all my heart.
35 Lead me in the path of your commandments,
for I delight in it.
36 Bend my heart toward your testimonies
and away from greedy profit!
37 Turn my eyes away from looking at worthless things;
give me life in your ways.[d]
38 Fulfill to your servant your promise,
which leads to the fear of you.

39 Turn away the disgrace that I dread,
for your judgments are good.
40 See how I yearn for your precepts!
Revive me by your righteousness!

ו *Waw*

41 Let your covenant love come to me, Yahweh,
your salvation according to your promise;
42 so that I can reply to those who mock me,
because I rely on your word.
43 Do not take the word of truth wholly out of my mouth,
for I hope in your judgments.
44 I will keep your law continually,
forever and ever.
45 I will go about at liberty,
because your precepts are what I seek.
46 I will speak of your testimonies before kings
and will not be put to shame.
47 I will delight in your commandments,
which I love.
48 I lift my hands toward your commandments, which I love,
and I reflect on your statutes.

ז *Zayin*

49 Remember the promise to your servant,
the one that gave me hope.
50 This is my comfort in my affliction:
your promise gives me life.
51 The arrogant utterly mock me,
but I do not turn aside from your law.
52 I remember your judgments from of old, Yahweh,
and I take comfort.
53 Hot indignation seizes me because of the wicked,
who forsake your law.
54 Your statutes have been my songs
in the house of my sojourning.

55 I remember your name in the night, Yahweh,
and I keep your law.
56 This has been my lot,
that I have kept your precepts.

ח *Heth*

57 My share is Yahweh;
I have said that I will keep your words.
58 With all my heart I have entreated your face;
show me grace as you have promised.
59 I have thought about my ways
and turned my steps back to your statutes.
60 I make haste without lingering
to keep your commandments.
61 The cords of the wicked wrap around me,
but I do not forget your law.
62 At midnight I rise to thank you
for your righteous judgments.
63 I am a companion of all who fear you,
of those who keep your precepts.
64 The earth, Yahweh, is full of your covenant love;
teach me your statutes!

ט *Teth*

65 You have dealt well with your servant,
Yahweh, according to your word.
66 Teach me good discernment and knowledge,
for I believe in your commandments.
67 Before I was afflicted I went astray,
but now I keep your promise.
68 You are good and do good;
teach me your statutes!
69 The arrogant smear me with lies,
but with all my heart I keep your precepts.
70 Their heart is thick like fat,
but I delight in your law.

71 It was good for me that I was afflicted,
so that I might learn your statutes.
72 The law of your mouth is better to me
than thousands of pieces of gold and silver.

י *Yod*

73 Your hands have made and shaped me;
give me understanding, that I may learn your commandments.
74 Those who fear you will see me and rejoice,
because I hope in your word.
75 I know, Yahweh, that your judgments are righteous,
and that in faithfulness you have afflicted me.
76 May your covenant love be my consolation,
as you promised your servant.
77 Let your compassion come to me, that I may live,
for your law is my delight.
78 May the proud be ashamed for twisting things against me with lies;
I will reflect on your instructions.
79 May those who fear you come back to me,
even those who know[e] your testimonies.
80 May my heart be whole in your statutes,
so that shame never comes on me.

כ *Kaph*

81 My soul faints for your salvation;
I hope in your word.
82 My eyes grow dim waiting for your promise;
"When will you console me?" I say.
83 Though I am like a wineskin shriveled by smoke,
your statutes have not slipped my mind.
84 How many are the days of your servant?
When will you bring judgment on those who persecute me?
85 The arrogant have dug pits for me,
people who do not live by your law.
86 All your commandments are faithful;
they persecute me with lies; help me!

87 They almost wiped me from the earth,
yet I have not let go of your precepts.
88 In your covenant love give me life,
and I will keep the testimony of your mouth.

ל *Lamedh*

89 Forever, Yahweh,
your word stands firm in the heavens.
90 Your faithfulness lasts through all generations;
you established the earth, and it stands.
91 By your judgments they stand to this day,
for all things are your servants.
92 If your law had not been my delight,
I would have perished in my affliction.
93 Never will I forget your precepts,
for through them you have revived me.
94 I am yours; save me,
for I have sought your precepts.
95 The wicked wait to destroy me,
but I give thought to your testimonies.
96 I have seen a limit to all perfection,
but your commandment is boundless.

מ *Mem*

97 Oh, how I love your law!
It is my meditation all day long.
98 Your commandment gives me more wisdom than my foes,
for it is mine forever.
99 I have more insight than all my teachers,
for your testimonies are my meditation.
100 I understand more than the elders,
for I keep your precepts.
101 I hold back my feet from every evil path,
so that I may keep your word.
102 From your judgments I have not swerved,
for it is you who have instructed me.

103 How sweet your promises are to my taste,
sweeter than honey to my mouth!
104 From your precepts I gain understanding;
therefore I hate every false path.

נ *Nun*

105 A lamp to my feet is your word,
a light along my path.
106 I have taken an oath and will carry it out:
to keep the judgments of your righteousness.
107 I am suffering terribly;
Yahweh, revive me as you promised!
108 Accept, Yahweh, the freewill offerings of my mouth,
and teach me your judgments.
109 I carry my life in my hands continually,[f]
but your law I do not forget.
110 The wicked have laid a snare for me,
but from your precepts I have not wandered.
111 Your testimonies are my inheritance forever,
for they are the joy of my heart.
112 I have bent my heart to do your statutes
forever, to the end.

ס *Samekh*

113 Those with a divided heart I hate;
your law is what I love.
114 You are my hiding place and my shield;
I hope in your word.
115 Away from me, you evildoers,
so that I may keep the commandments of my God!
116 Uphold me as you promised, so that I live,
and do not let my hope end in shame!
117 Support me, and I will be rescued;
I will keep my gaze on your statutes always.
118 You reject all who stray from your statutes,
for their deceitfulness is futile.

119 You remove the wicked of the earth like slag;
that is why I love your testimonies.
120 My flesh shudders for dread of you,
and I am afraid of your judgments.

ע *Ayin*

121 I have done what is just and right;
do not abandon me to my oppressors!
122 Guarantee your servant's welfare;
do not let the arrogant oppress me!
123 My eyes fail with watching for your salvation
and for your righteous promise.
124 Deal with your servant according to your covenant love,
and teach me your statutes.
125 I am your servant; give me understanding,
that I may know your testimonies!
126 It is time for Yahweh to act,
for your law has been broken.
127 Therefore I love your commandments
more than gold, more than fine gold.
128 Therefore I count all your precepts right in everything;[g]
I hate every false path.

פ *Pe*

129 Your testimonies are wonderful;
therefore my soul keeps them.
130 The unfolding of your words gives light;
it gives understanding to the simple.
131 I open my mouth wide and pant,
for I long for your commandments.
132 Turn toward me and show me grace,
as is right for those who love your name.
133 Make my steps firm by your promise,
and let no iniquity rule over me.
134 Ransom me from the oppression of men,
and I will keep your precepts.

135 Let your face shine on your servant,
and instruct me in your statutes.
136 My eyes pour down rivers of water
because your law goes unkept.

צ *Tsadhe*

137 Righteous are you, Yahweh,
and upright are your judgments.
138 In righteousness you have commanded your testimonies,
in utter faithfulness.
139 My zeal has worn me out,
for my adversaries have forgotten your words.
140 Your promise is well tested,
and your servant loves it.
141 Insignificant and scorned though I am,
I have not forgotten your precepts.
142 Your righteousness is an everlasting righteousness,
and your instruction is truth.
143 Trouble and anguish have found me,
but your commandments are my delight.
144 Your testimonies are righteous forever;
give me understanding, that I may live.

ק *Qoph*

145 I call with all my heart; answer me, Yahweh!
I will keep your statutes.
146 To you I call out—rescue me,
so that I may guard your testimonies.
147 I rise before dawn and cry for help;
I hope in your words.[h]
148 My eyes are awake before the night watches,
that I may meditate on your promise.
149 Hear my voice according to your covenant love;
Yahweh, give me life according to your justice.
150 Those who pursue evil schemes draw near;
they are far from your law.

151 You are near, Yahweh,
and all your commandments are truth.
152 Long ago I learned from your testimonies
that you founded them forever.

ר *Resh*

153 Look on my affliction and rescue me,
for I do not forget your law.
154 Take up my case and redeem me;
revive me as you have promised!
155 Far from the wicked is salvation,
because they do not search out your statutes.
156 Great is your compassion, Yahweh;
give me life according to your judgments.
157 Many are my persecutors and my foes,
but I do not swerve from your testimonies.
158 I look at the faithless and feel disgust,
because they do not keep your promise.
159 Look how I love your instructions!
Yahweh, revive me in keeping with your steadfast love.
160 The sum of your word is truth,
and every one of your righteous judgments lasts forever.

ש *Sin and Shin*

161 Princes persecute me without cause,
but my heart stands in awe of your words.[i]
162 I rejoice at your promise
like one who finds great plunder.
163 Falsehood I hate and detest;
your law I love.
164 Seven times a day I praise you
for your righteous judgments.
165 Great peace belongs to those who love your law;
nothing makes them stumble.
166 I hope for your salvation, Yahweh,
and I do your commandments.

167 My soul keeps your testimonies;
I love them greatly.
168 I have kept your precepts and your testimonies,
since all my ways lie open before you.

ת *Taw*

169 Let my cry come near before you, Yahweh;
give me understanding according to your word!
170 Let my plea come before you;
rescue me according to your promise!
171 My lips will pour out praise,
for you teach me your statutes.
172 Let my tongue sing out your promise,
since every commandment of yours is righteous.
173 Let your hand be ready to help me,
for I have chosen your precepts.
174 I long for your salvation, Yahweh,
and your law is my delight.
175 May my soul live to praise you,
and may your judgments come to my aid.
176 I have strayed like a lost sheep; seek your servant,
for I do not forget your commandments.

Notes

- a (119:1) Psalm 119 is the longest psalm and the longest chapter in the Bible. It is an acrostic in twenty-two stanzas, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet; each of the eight lines in a stanza begins with that stanza's letter. Nearly every verse names God's word with one of eight terms: law (torah), testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, judgments, word (dabar), and promise or saying (ʾimrah).
- b (119:28) Or "drips away," "melts."
- c (119:33) Or "as my reward."
- d (119:37) So many Hebrew manuscripts; the Masoretic Text reads "your way."
- e (119:79) So the qere; the ketiv reads "that they may know."
- f (119:109) That is, constantly in danger.
- g (119:128) The Hebrew of this line is difficult.
- h (119:147) So the qere; the ketiv reads "your word."
- i (119:161) So the qere; the ketiv reads "your word."

Chapter 120

A song of ascents.

1 To Yahweh I called in my trouble,
  and he answered me.
2 Yahweh, rescue my soul from lying lips,
  from a tongue of deceit!
3 What shall he give you, what further shall he add to you,
  O lying tongue?
4 A warrior's sharpened arrows,
  with glowing coals of the broom tree!
5 Woe to me, that I live as an alien in Meshech,
  that I dwell among the tents of Kedar![b]
6 Too long my soul has had its home
  with those who hate peace.
7 I am for peace, but when I speak,
  they are for war.

Notes

- a (120 title) Psalms 120–134 each carry the title "A song of ascents" (Hebrew shir hammaʿalot). They are widely understood as songs sung by pilgrims "going up" to Jerusalem for the festivals; Jewish tradition also linked them with the fifteen steps of the temple. Psalm 121's title has a slightly different wording ("A song for the ascents").
- b (120:5) Meshech lay far to the north (near the Black Sea) and Kedar in the Arabian desert; the names stand for hostile, distant peoples.

Chapter 121

A song for the ascents.

1 I lift my eyes to the mountains—
  where does my help come from?
2 My help comes from Yahweh,
  the Maker of heaven and earth.
3 He will not let your foot slip;
  your guardian will not doze.
4 Look, he who guards Israel
  neither dozes nor sleeps.

5 Yahweh is your guardian;
Yahweh is your shade at your right hand.
6 The sun will not harm you by day,
nor the moon at night.
7 Yahweh will guard you from all harm;
he will guard your life.
8 Yahweh will guard your going out and your coming in
from now on and forevermore.

Chapter 122

A song of ascents. Of David.

1 I rejoiced when they said to me,
"Let us go to the house of Yahweh!"
2 Our feet have been standing
within your gates, Jerusalem—
3 Jerusalem, built as a city
bound firmly together,
4 where the tribes go up, the tribes of Yah,
as was decreed for Israel,[a]
to give thanks to the name of Yahweh.
5 For there the thrones for judgment stand,
the thrones of the house of David.
6 Ask for Jerusalem's peace![b]
"May all who love you live at ease!
7 May peace be within your ramparts,
security within your towers!"
8 For the sake of my kin and my companions
I will speak: "Within you be peace!"
9 For the sake of the house of Yahweh our God,
I will seek your good.

Notes

- a (122:4) Hebrew "a testimony for Israel."
- b (122:6) The Hebrew plays on the sounds of shalom (peace), Yerushalaim (Jerusalem), and shalvah (ease, security).

Chapter 123

A song of ascents.

1 Toward you I raise my eyes,
you who sit enthroned in the heavens!
2 Look—as the eyes of servants are on the hand of their lord,
as the eyes of a maid are on the hand of her mistress,
so our eyes are on Yahweh our God,
until he shows us grace.
3 Be gracious to us, Yahweh, be gracious to us,
for we have had more than our fill of contempt.
4 Too long our soul has been sated
with the scorn of the complacent,
with the contempt of the arrogant.

Chapter 124

A song of ascents. Of David.

1 "If it had not been Yahweh who was for us"—
let Israel now say—
2 "if it had not been Yahweh who was for us
when people rose up against us,
3 then they would have swallowed us alive
when their anger blazed against us;
4 then the flood would have carried us off;
the torrent would have rolled over our soul;
5 then over our soul
the raging waters would have gone."
6 Blessed be Yahweh,
who has not handed us over as prey for their teeth!
7 Our soul has escaped like a bird
from the fowler's snare;
the snare is broken,
and we have escaped!
8 Our help is in the name of Yahweh,
the Maker of heaven and earth.

Chapter 125

A song of ascents.

1 Those who trust in Yahweh are like Mount Zion,
which cannot be shaken but stands forever.
2 As the mountains surround Jerusalem,
so Yahweh surrounds his people,
from now on and forevermore.
3 For the scepter of wickedness will not rest
on the land allotted to the righteous,
so that the righteous do not reach out their hands to do wrong.
4 Do good, Yahweh, to those who are good,
and to those who are upright in their hearts!
5 But those who turn aside to their crooked ways
Yahweh will lead away with the evildoers.
Peace be on Israel!

Chapter 126

A song of ascents.

1 When Yahweh restored the fortunes of Zion,[a]
we were like those who dream.
2 Then our mouths were full of laughter,
our tongues of joyful singing.
Among the nations people said,
"Yahweh has done great things for them."
3 Yahweh has done great things for us;
we are glad.
4 Restore our fortunes,[b] Yahweh,
like streams in the Negev![c]
5 Those who sow in tears
will reap with shouts of joy.
6 He who goes out weeping,
carrying the seed for sowing,
will surely come home with shouts of joy,
carrying his sheaves.

Notes

- a (126:1) Or “brought back the captives of Zion.”
- b (126:4) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant form of the same noun.
- c (126:4) The dry south country, where seasonal streambeds suddenly run full after rain.

Chapter 127

A song of ascents. Of Solomon.

1 Unless Yahweh builds the house,
its builders labor over it in vain.
Unless Yahweh guards the city,
the watchman stays awake in vain.
2 It is useless to get up at dawn
and stay up into the night,
eating the bread of hard toil;
for to his beloved he gives sleep.[a]
3 Look, children are a heritage from Yahweh,
the fruit of the womb a reward.
4 Like arrows in a warrior’s hand
are sons born in one’s youth.
5 Happy is the man
who has filled his quiver with them!
They will not be put to shame
when they speak with enemies in the gate.

Notes

- a (127:2) Or “he provides for his beloved while they sleep.” “Beloved” (yedid) echoes Jedidiah, a name of Solomon (2 Samuel 12:25).

Chapter 128

A song of ascents.

1 Happy is everyone who fears Yahweh,
who walks in his ways!
2 You will eat the fruit of the labor of your hands;
you will be happy, and it will go well with you.
3 Your wife within your house
will be like a vine heavy with fruit;

around your table your children
will be like young olive trees.
4 Look, this is how the man will be blessed
who fears Yahweh.
5 Yahweh bless you out of Zion!
May you look on Jerusalem's good
every day you live!
6 May you see your children's children!
Peace be on Israel!

Chapter 129

A song of ascents.

1 "Many times from my youth they have assailed me"—
let Israel now say—
2 "many times from my youth they have assailed me,
yet they have not overcome me.
3 Plowmen plowed across my back;
they made their furrows long."[a]
4 Yahweh is righteous;
he has cut the cords of the wicked.
5 Let all who hate Zion
be put to shame and turned back!
6 Let them be like grass on the rooftops,
which dries up before it can be pulled up,
7 grass that fills no reaper's hand,
no armful for one who binds sheaves,
8 nor do those who pass by say,
"The blessing of Yahweh be on you!
We bless you in the name of Yahweh!"

Notes

- a (129:3) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant spelling.

Chapter 130

A song of ascents.

1 Out of the depths I call to you, Yahweh!

2 Lord, hear my voice!
Let your ears be attentive
to the voice of my pleas for mercy!
3 If you, Yah, kept a record of iniquities,
Lord, who could stand?
4 But forgiveness is with you,
that you may be held in awe.
5 I wait for Yahweh; my whole soul waits,
and I put my hope in his word.
6 My soul waits for the Lord
more than watchmen for the morning,
more than watchmen for the morning.
7 Israel, hope in Yahweh!
For with Yahweh there is covenant love,
and with him is abundant redemption.
8 And he will redeem Israel
from all its iniquities.

Chapter 131

A song of ascents. Of David.

1 Yahweh, there is no pride in my heart,
no haughtiness in my eyes;
I do not reach after great matters,
or things too wondrous for me.
2 Instead, I have made my soul calm and still,
like a child weaned from its mother's milk;
my soul within me is like that child.
3 Israel, hope in Yahweh
from now on and forevermore.

Chapter 132

A song of ascents.

1 Remember, Yahweh, in David's favor,
all the hardship he endured,

2 how he swore to Yahweh
and vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob:
3 “I will not enter the tent of my house
or get into my bed;
4 I will not give sleep to my eyes
or slumber to my eyelids,
5 until I find a place for Yahweh,
a dwelling for the Mighty One of Jacob.”
6 Look, we heard of it in Ephrathah;[a]
we found it in the fields of Jaar.[b]
7 “Let us enter where he dwells;
let us bow low at his footstool!”
8 Arise, Yahweh, and go to your resting place,
you and the ark of your might.
9 Let your priests be clothed with righteousness,
and let your faithful ones shout for joy.
10 For the sake of your servant David,
do not reject your anointed king.[c]
11 Yahweh swore to David in truth,
an oath he will not take back:
“From the fruit of your body
I will place one on your throne.
12 If your sons keep my covenant
and my testimonies that I will teach them,
their sons also forever
will sit on your throne.”
13 For Yahweh has chosen Zion;
he has desired it as his dwelling:
14 “Here is my resting place forevermore;
here I will make my home, for I have longed for it.
15 I will richly bless her provisions;
I will satisfy her poor with bread.
16 Her priests I will clothe with salvation,
and her faithful ones will shout aloud for joy.

17 There I will cause a horn to spring up for David;
I have set out a lamp for my anointed one.
18 I will dress his enemies in shame,
but on his head his crown will gleam."

Notes

- a (132:6) Possibly the region of Bethlehem (Ruth 4:11; Micah 5:2), or of Kiriath-jearim.
- b (132:6) "Forest," probably Kiriath-jearim, where the ark stayed for twenty years (1 Samuel 7:1–2).
- c (132:10) Verses 8–10 are closely paralleled in 2 Chronicles 6:41–42.

Chapter 133

A song of ascents. Of David.

1 Look how good and how pleasant it is
when brothers live together in unity!
2 It is like the fine oil on the head,
flowing down on the beard,
on Aaron's beard,
flowing down to the neck of his garments.
3 It is like the dew of Hermon
that falls on the mountains of Zion.
For there Yahweh has commanded the blessing:
life forevermore.

Chapter 134

A song of ascents.

1 Come, bless Yahweh,
all you servants of Yahweh,
who stand by night in the house of Yahweh!
2 Lift up your hands toward the sanctuary
and bless Yahweh!
3 May Yahweh bless you from Zion,
he who made heaven and earth!

Chapter 135

1 Hallelujah!
Praise the name of Yahweh!
Give praise, you servants of Yahweh,
2 you who stand in the house of Yahweh,
in the courts of the house of our God!
3 Praise Yah, for Yahweh is good;
sing to his name, for it is lovely!
4 For Yah has chosen Jacob for himself,
Israel as his treasured possession.
5 For I know that Yahweh is great,
and that our Lord is above all gods.
6 Whatever Yahweh pleases, he does,
in the heavens and on the earth,
in the seas and all the deeps.
7 He brings up the mists from the far edges of the earth;
he forms lightning bolts to go with the rain
and draws the wind out of his treasuries.
8 He struck down the firstborn of Egypt,
of human and of beast alike.
9 Into your midst, Egypt, he sent signs and wonders,
on Pharaoh and on all who served him.
10 He struck down many nations
and killed mighty kings—
11 Sihon king of the Amorites,
Og king of Bashan,
and all the kingdoms of Canaan—
12 and he handed over their land as a heritage,
a heritage to Israel his people.
13 Yahweh, your name endures forever,
your renown, Yahweh, through all generations.
14 For Yahweh will vindicate his people
and have compassion on his servants.[a]

15 The idols of the nations are silver and gold,
the work of human hands.
16 Mouths they have, yet they cannot speak;
eyes they have, yet they cannot see;
17 ears they have, yet they cannot hear,
and no breath is in their mouths at all.
18 Their makers will grow like them,
and so will everyone who relies on them.[b]
19 House of Israel, bless Yahweh!
House of Aaron, bless Yahweh!
20 House of Levi, bless Yahweh!
You who fear Yahweh, bless Yahweh!
21 Blessed from Zion be Yahweh,
who dwells in Jerusalem!
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (135:14) Verse 14 repeats Deuteronomy 32:36.
- b (135:18) Verses 15–18 closely follow Psalm 115:4–8.

Chapter 136

1 Give thanks to Yahweh, for he is good,
for his covenant love endures forever.[a]
2 Give thanks to the God of gods,
for his covenant love endures forever.
3 Give thanks to the Lord of lords,
for his covenant love endures forever;
4 to him who alone does great wonders,
for his covenant love endures forever;
5 to him who by understanding made the heavens,
for his covenant love endures forever;
6 to him who spread out the earth above the waters,
for his covenant love endures forever;
7 to him who made the great lights,
for his covenant love endures forever—

8 the sun to govern the day,
for his covenant love endures forever;
9 the moon and stars to rule over the night,
for his covenant love endures forever;
10 to him who struck Egypt through their firstborn,
for his covenant love endures forever,
11 and brought Israel out from among them,
for his covenant love endures forever,
12 with a strong hand and an outstretched arm,
for his covenant love endures forever;
13 to him who split the Red Sea in two,
for his covenant love endures forever,
14 and made Israel pass through the middle of it,
for his covenant love endures forever,
15 but shook off Pharaoh and his army into the Red Sea,
for his covenant love endures forever;
16 to him who led his people through the wilderness,
for his covenant love endures forever;
17 to him who struck great kings,
for his covenant love endures forever,
18 and killed majestic kings,
for his covenant love endures forever—
19 Sihon king of the Amorites,
for his covenant love endures forever,
20 and Og king of Bashan,
for his covenant love endures forever—
21 and gave their land as an inheritance,
for his covenant love endures forever,
22 an inheritance for Israel his servant,
for his covenant love endures forever;
23 who remembered us when we were brought low,
for his covenant love endures forever,
24 and snatched us from our foes,
for his covenant love endures forever;

25 who gives food to all flesh,
for his covenant love endures forever.
26 Give thanks to the God of heaven,
for his covenant love endures forever.

Notes

- a (136:1) Every verse of this psalm ends with the same response, "for his covenant love endures forever" (ki leʿolam khasdo), apparently sung by the congregation in answer to a leader. Jewish tradition calls it "the Great Hallel."

Chapter 137

1 By the rivers of Babylon—
there we sat down and wept
when we remembered Zion.
2 On the poplars[a] there
we hung up our lyres.
3 There our captors
requested songs from us,
and those who mocked us wanted entertainment:
"Sing us a song from Zion!"
4 How could we sing a song of Yahweh
on foreign soil?
5 If I forget you, Jerusalem,
let my right hand forget its skill!
6 Let my tongue stick to my palate
if I do not remember you,
if I do not value Jerusalem
more than my greatest joy!
7 Remember, Yahweh, against the sons of Edom
the day of Jerusalem,
how they said, "Strip it bare, strip it bare,
down to its foundations!"
8 Daughter of Babylon, you destroyer soon destroyed,
happy is he who pays you back
the full measure you dealt to us!

9 Happy is he who takes hold of your little ones
and smashes them on the rock![b]

Notes

- a (137:2) Traditionally "willows"; the tree is probably the Euphrates poplar.
- b (137:9) The psalm ends with a raw cry for retribution from people who had seen their own children slaughtered (compare Isaiah 13:16; Hosea 13:16; Nahum 3:10). It voices the exiles' anguish and hands vengeance over to God in prayer (compare Deuteronomy 32:35; Romans 12:19); it is not a command to be carried out. The CJT translates it without softening.

Chapter 138

Of David.

1 I give you thanks with all my heart;
before the gods[a] I sing your praise.
2 I bow down toward your holy temple
and give thanks to your name
for your covenant love and your faithfulness,
for you have made your promise great, above all your name.[b]
3 The day I called out, you answered me;
you emboldened me, putting strength in my soul.
4 All the kings of the earth will give you thanks, Yahweh,
when they have heard the words of your mouth,
5 and they will sing of the ways of Yahweh,
for great is the glory of Yahweh.
6 For though Yahweh is high, he looks on the lowly,
but the haughty he knows from far away.
7 Though I walk through the thick of trouble,
you preserve my life;
you put out your hand against my enemies' rage,
and your right hand rescues me.
8 Yahweh will complete his purpose for me.
Yahweh, your covenant love endures forever.
Do not let go of the works of your hands!

Notes

- a (138:1) Hebrew ʾelohim; possibly the heavenly beings, or the gods of the nations (so many interpreters), or rulers. The Septuagint has "angels."

- b (138:2) The Hebrew is unusual; it may mean that God has exalted his word even beyond all that his name had revealed, or "you have exalted your name and your word above all things."

Chapter 139

To the choirmaster. Of David. A psalm.

1 Yahweh, you have searched me and you know me.
2 Whether I sit or stand, you know it;
you perceive my thoughts from afar.
3 You measure out my journeys and my resting;
you know all my ways through and through.
4 Before there is a word on my tongue,
look, Yahweh, you know it completely.
5 You hem me in, behind and before;
you have laid your hand on me.
6 Such knowledge is too wonderful for me;[a]
it is too high—I cannot reach it.
7 Where could I go from your Spirit?
Where could I flee from your presence?
8 If I go up to the heavens, you are there;
if I make my bed in Sheol, you are there!
9 If I take the wings of the dawn
and settle at the far side of the sea,
10 even there your hand will lead me,
and your right hand will hold me fast.
11 If I say, "The darkness will surely hide me,
and the light around me will turn to night,"
12 to you even darkness is not dark;
night is as bright as day,
for darkness and light are alike to you.
13 For you formed my inward parts;[b]
you wove me together in my mother's womb.
14 I praise you, for I am made in an awe-inspiring and wonderful way.[c]
Wonderful are your works;
my soul knows it very well.

15 My frame was not hidden from you
when I was made in secret,
intricately woven in the depths of the earth.
16 Your eyes saw me while I was yet unformed;
in your book were all recorded
the days fashioned for me,
when as yet there was not one of them.[d]
17 How precious to me are your thoughts, God!
How vast is the sum of them!
18 If I tried to count them, they would outnumber the sand.
I wake up, and I am still with you.
19 If only you would slay the wicked, God!
Men of bloodshed, get away from me!
20 They speak of you with wicked intent;
your adversaries take your name in vain.[e]
21 Do I not hate those who hate you, Yahweh?
Do I not loathe those who rise up against you?
22 With perfect hatred I hate them;
they have become enemies to me.
23 Search me out, God, and know my heart!
Try me, and know my troubled thoughts!
24 See whether there is any hurtful way in me,
and lead me in the everlasting way!

Notes

- a (139:6) So the qere; the ketiv has a variant form of the same word.
- b (139:13) Hebrew "kidneys," the seat of the deepest emotions.
- c (139:14) The Hebrew is difficult; the Septuagint and some other ancient versions read "for you are awe-inspiring and wonderful."
- d (139:16) The final line follows the ketiv (lo, "not"). The qere reads lo, "to him / for it," giving a sense such as "and for it there was one of them." The verse is notoriously difficult.
- e (139:20) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.

Chapter 140

To the choirmaster. A psalm of David.

1 Rescue me, Yahweh, from evil men;
guard me from men of violence,
2 who scheme evil in their hearts
and every day stir up battles.
3 They make their tongues sharp as a snake's;
the poison of vipers is behind their lips. Selah
4 Keep me, Yahweh, from the hands of the wicked;
guard me from men of violence,
who plan to trip up my steps.
5 The proud have hidden a trap for me,
and ropes;
they have stretched out a net along the road;
they have laid traps for me. Selah
6 I say to Yahweh, "You are my God."
Give ear, Yahweh, to the voice of my pleas for mercy!
7 Yahweh, my Lord, the strength of my salvation,
you have shielded my head in the day of battle.
8 Do not grant, Yahweh, the desires of the wicked;
do not let his plot succeed,
or they will exalt themselves. Selah
9 As for the heads of those who surround me,
let the trouble of their own lips cover them!
10 Let burning coals fall on them![a]
Let them be cast into the fire,
into pits, never to rise again!
11 Let no slanderer find a footing in the land;
let disaster hunt the violent man down, blow upon blow!
12 I know[b] that Yahweh will uphold the cause of the afflicted
and justice for the needy.
13 Surely the righteous will give thanks to your name;
the upright will dwell in your presence.

Notes

- a (140:10) So the qere; the ketiv may be read "let him bring down burning coals on them."
- b (140:12) So the qere; the ketiv reads "you know."

Chapter 141

A psalm of David.

1 Yahweh, I call to you; hurry to me!
Give ear to my voice when I call to you!
2 May my prayer rise before you like incense,
my raised hands like the evening sacrifice.
3 Set a guard, Yahweh, over my mouth;
keep watch over the door of my lips!
4 Do not let my heart incline to anything evil,
to busy myself with wicked deeds
alongside men who do wrong,
and let me not eat of their delicacies!
5 Let a righteous person hit me—it is a kindness;
let him rebuke me—it is like oil on my head;
my head will not turn away from it.
But my prayer will always oppose the actions of the wicked.[a]
6 When their judges are thrown down from the sides of the cliff,
then they will hear my words, for they are pleasant.
7 As when one plows and breaks up the ground,
so our bones are scattered at the mouth of Sheol.
8 But my eyes are toward you, Yahweh, my Lord;
in you I take refuge; do not pour out my life!
9 Keep me from the trap they have laid for me
and from the snares of evildoers!
10 Let the wicked fall into their own nets,
while I pass by in safety.

Notes

- a (141:5) Verses 5–7 are among the most obscure in the Psalter; the translation is tentative.

Chapter 142

A maskil of David, when he was in the cave. A prayer.

1 With my voice I cry out to Yahweh;
with my voice I plead with Yahweh for mercy.

2 I pour out my complaint before him;
I tell my trouble before him.
3 When my spirit grows faint within me,
you are the one who knows my path!
On the path where I walk
they have hidden a trap for me.
4 Look on my right side and see:
nobody pays any attention to me;
I have nowhere to flee;
no one cares about my life.
5 I cry to you, Yahweh;
I say, "You are my refuge,
my portion in the land of the living."
6 Pay attention to my cry,
for I am brought very low!
Rescue me from my pursuers,
for they are too strong for me!
7 Lead me out of prison
so that I can praise your name!
The righteous will surround me
because you will be good to me.

Notes

- a (142 title) Compare 1 Samuel 22:1; 24:3; and the title of Psalm 57.

Chapter 143

A psalm of David.

1 Hear my prayer, Yahweh;
listen to my pleading!
Answer me in your faithfulness and in your righteousness!
2 Do not put your servant on trial,
for no one alive is righteous in your sight.
3 For the enemy has hunted my soul;
he has beaten my life down into the dust;
he has made me dwell in darkness like the long dead.

4 And so my spirit fails within me;
my heart is stunned inside me.
5 I call to mind the days of old;
I reflect on all your deeds;
I muse on what your hands have made.
6 I spread out my hands to you;
my soul thirsts for you like a parched land. Selah
7 Make haste to answer me, Yahweh!
My spirit is spent!
Do not turn your face away,
or I will be like those who sink into the pit.
8 In the morning let me hear of your covenant love,
for my trust is in you.
Show me the road to walk on,
for to you I raise my soul.
9 Deliver me from my enemies, Yahweh!
With you I have taken shelter.[a]
10 Teach me to carry out your will,
for you are my God!
May your good Spirit guide me
on even ground!
11 For your name's sake, Yahweh, keep me alive!
In your righteousness bring my soul out of trouble!
12 And in your covenant love cut off my enemies,
and destroy all the adversaries of my soul,
for I am your servant.

Notes

- a (143:9) The Hebrew is uncertain; the Septuagint has "to you I have fled."

Chapter 144

Of David.

1 Blessed be Yahweh, my rock,
who trains my hands for war,
my fingers for battle;

2 my covenant love[a] and my fortress,
my stronghold and my deliverer,
my shield, in whom I take refuge,
who subdues my people[b] under me.
3 Yahweh, what is man that you take note of him,
the son of man that you give him a thought?
4 Man is like a breath;
his days are like a passing shadow.
5 Yahweh, bend your heavens and come down!
Touch the mountains so that they smoke!
6 Flash out lightning and scatter them;
send your arrows and rout them!
7 Stretch out your hands from on high;
set me free and rescue me from the great waters,
from the hand of foreigners,
8 whose mouths speak falsehood
and whose right hand is a right hand of lies.
9 God, I will sing a new song to you;
on a ten-stringed harp I will make music to you,
10 to him who gives victory to kings,
who sets David his servant free from the cruel sword.
11 Set me free and rescue me
from the hand of foreigners,
whose mouths speak falsehood
and whose right hand is a right hand of lies.
12 May our sons in their youth
be like plants grown tall,
our daughters like corner pillars
carved for the building of a palace;
13 may our barns be full,
supplying produce of every kind;
may our flocks bring forth thousands,
tens of thousands in our fields;

14 may our oxen be laden;[c]
  may no wall be breached and no one led captive,
  and no wailing be heard in our streets!
15 Happy is the people for whom it is so!
  Happy is the people whose God is Yahweh!

Notes

- a (144:2) Hebrew khasdi, "my covenant love"—that is, the God who shows me covenant love. Psalm 18:2 and 2 Samuel 22 have "my rock."
- b (144:2) Many Hebrew manuscripts, the Aramaic, and Syriac read "peoples" (compare Psalm 18:47; 2 Samuel 22:48).
- c (144:14) Or "may our chieftains be firmly established." The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.

Chapter 145

A song of praise. Of David.

1 I will lift you up, my God and King,
  and praise your name forever and ever.
2 Each day I will bless you
  and give praise to your name for all time and beyond.
3 Great is Yahweh and most worthy of praise;
  his greatness is beyond searching out.
4 One generation will commend your works to the next
  and tell of your mighty acts.
5 I will ponder the glorious splendor of your majesty
  and the record of your wonders.[b]
6 They will speak of the power of your awesome deeds,
  and I will declare your greatness.[c]
7 They will pour out the memory of your abundant goodness
  and sing joyfully of your righteousness.
8 Gracious and compassionate is Yahweh,
  slow to anger and great in covenant love.
9 Yahweh is good toward everyone;
  his mercy rests on all his works.
10 All your works will give you thanks, Yahweh,
  and your faithful ones will bless you.

11 They will speak of the glory of your kingdom
and tell of your might,
12 to make known to the children of men his mighty acts
and the glorious splendor of his kingdom.
13 Your kingdom lasts through all the ages,
and your rule continues in every generation.
[God is faithful in everything he says
and kind in everything he does.][d]
14 Yahweh holds up all who are falling
and raises up all who are bowed down.
15 All eyes wait on you,
and you give them their food when it is due.
16 You open your hand
and satisfy the desire of every living thing.
17 Yahweh is righteous in all his ways
and faithful in all his works.
18 Yahweh is near to all who call on him,
to all who call on him in truth.
19 He grants what those who fear him long for;
he listens to their cry and rescues them.
20 Yahweh watches over all who love him,
but all the wicked he will destroy.
21 My mouth will speak the praise of Yahweh,
and let all flesh bless his holy name
forever and ever.

Notes

- a (145 title) Psalm 145 is an alphabetic acrostic: each verse begins with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In the standard Hebrew text the nun (נ) line, which should come between verses 13 and 14, is missing. A nun line is found in the Psalms Scroll from Qumran (11QPs-a), in the Septuagint and Syriac, and in one medieval Masoretic manuscript. The CJT includes it in brackets at the end of verse 13. Psalms 9–10, 25, 34, 37, 111, 112, and 119 are also acrostics. In 11QPs-a, each verse of this psalm is followed by the refrain "Blessed be Yahweh and blessed be his name forever and ever." This is the only psalm titled tehillah, "song of praise," the word from which the Hebrew name of the whole book, Tehillim, comes.

- b (145:5) The Septuagint and 11QPs-a read “They will speak of the glorious splendor of your majesty, and tell of your wondrous works.”
- c (145:6) So the qere; the ketiv reads “your great deeds.”
- d (145:13) The bracketed nun line (Hebrew neʾeman, “faithful”) is not in the standard Masoretic Text. It is attested in 11QPs-a (which reads “God”), the Septuagint (which reads “the Lord,” suggesting Hebrew YHWH), the Syriac, and one Masoretic manuscript. Compare verse 17, which it closely resembles. The CJT includes it because it completes the acrostic and has early, independent support; readers may treat it as a probable but uncertain part of the text.

Chapter 146

1 Hallelujah![a]
Praise Yahweh, my soul!
2 I will praise Yahweh as long as I live;
I will sing to my God while I have my being.
3 Do not put your trust in princes,
in a son of man, who cannot save.
4 His breath departs; he returns to his ground;
on that very day his plans perish.
5 Happy is he who has the God of Jacob for his help,
who rests his hope on Yahweh his God,
6 the Maker of heaven and earth,
the sea, and all that is in them,
who keeps faith forever;
7 who executes justice for the oppressed,
who gives food to the hungry.
Yahweh sets the prisoners free;
8 Yahweh opens the eyes of the blind;
Yahweh raises up those who are bowed down;
Yahweh loves the righteous;
9 Yahweh watches over the sojourners;
he upholds the fatherless and the widow,
but the way of the wicked he turns upside down.
10 Yahweh will reign forever,
your God, Zion, for all generations.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (146:1) Psalms 146–150, the closing "Hallel" of the Psalter, each begin and end with "Hallelujah" ("Praise Yah!").

Chapter 147

1 Hallelujah!
For it is good to sing praises to our God;
for it is pleasant, and praise is fitting.[a]
2 Yahweh builds up Jerusalem;
he gathers the outcasts of Israel.
3 He heals the brokenhearted
and binds up their wounds.
4 He counts out the number of the stars;
he calls each of them by name.
5 Our Lord is great and enormously powerful;
his understanding cannot be measured.
6 Yahweh raises up the lowly;
he throws the wicked to the ground.
7 Sing to Yahweh with thanksgiving;
make music to our God on the lyre!
8 He wraps the sky in clouds;
he readies rain for the earth;
he makes the hills sprout grass.
9 He gives the animals their food,
and the young ravens when they call.
10 He takes no delight in the strength of the horse,
nor pleasure in the legs of a man;
11 Yahweh takes pleasure in those who fear him,
in those who hope in his covenant love.
12 Praise Yahweh, Jerusalem!
Praise your God, Zion!
13 For he has made firm the bars of your gates;
he has blessed your sons within you.
14 He makes peace within your borders;
he satisfies you with the finest wheat.

15 He dispatches his command to the earth;
his word races along.
16 He spreads out snow like wool;
he strews the frost like ash.
17 He hurls down his hail like crumbs;
who can stand before his cold?
18 He sends his word and they melt;
he stirs his wind, and the waters run.
19 He declares his word[b] to Jacob,
his statutes and rules to Israel.
20 He has not dealt this way with any other nation;
they do not know his rules.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (147:1) The Septuagint divides this psalm into two: verses 1–11 are its Psalm 146, and verses 12–20 its Psalm 147. From here on the Greek and Latin numbering again matches the Hebrew (see the note on the numbering of the Psalms at Psalm 1).
- b (147:19) So the qere; the ketiv reads "his words."

Chapter 148

1 Hallelujah!
Praise Yahweh from the heavens;
praise him in the heights!
2 Praise him, all his angels;
praise him, all his host![a]
3 Praise him, sun and moon;
praise him, all you shining stars!
4 Praise him, you heaven of heavens,
you waters that are above the skies!
5 Let them praise the name of Yahweh,
for he commanded and they were created.
6 He set them in place forever and ever;
he fixed a limit that will not be passed.
7 Praise Yahweh from the earth,
you sea monsters and all deeps,

8 Fire and hail, snow and fog,
storm wind that does what he says!
9 Mountains and all hills,
fruit trees and all cedars!
10 Wild animals and all livestock,
creeping things and flying birds!
11 Kings of the earth and all peoples,
princes and all rulers of the earth!
12 Young men and young women alike,
old and young together!
13 Let them praise the name of Yahweh,
for his name alone is exalted;
his majesty is above earth and heaven.
14 He has lifted high a horn for his people,
a cause of praise for all his faithful ones,
for the children of Israel, a people close to him.
Hallelujah!

Notes

- a (148:2) So the qere; the ketiv reads “hosts.”

Chapter 149

1 Hallelujah!
Sing to Yahweh a new song,
his praise in the assembly of the faithful!
2 Let Israel rejoice in his Maker;
let the children of Zion delight in their King!
3 Let them praise his name with dancing,
making music to him with tambourine and lyre!
4 For Yahweh takes pleasure in his people;
he crowns the humble with salvation.
5 Let the faithful exult in glory;
let them sing for joy on their beds.
6 Let praises to God be in their mouths
and a double-edged sword in their hands,

7 to carry out vengeance on the nations
and punishment on the peoples,
8 to bind their kings with chains
and their nobles with fetters of iron,
9 to carry out on them the judgment written!
This is the honor of all his faithful ones.
Hallelujah!

Chapter 150

1 Hallelujah!
Praise God in his sanctuary;
praise him in his mighty expanse![a]
2 Praise him for his mighty deeds;
praise him for his surpassing greatness!
3 Praise him with the sounding of the horn;
praise him with lute and lyre!
4 Praise him with tambourine and dancing;
praise him with strings and flute!
5 Praise him with clashing cymbals;
praise him with resounding cymbals!
6 Let everything that has breath praise Yah!
Hallelujah![b]

Notes

- a (150:1) Psalm 150 is the closing doxology of Book Five and of the whole Psalter. Each of the first four books ends with a short blessing (41:13; 72:18–19; 89:52; 106:48); the fifth ends with an entire psalm of praise, in which "praise" (hallelu) sounds thirteen times.
- b (150:6) The Psalms Scroll from Qumran (11QPs-a, first century AD) contains many of the psalms of Books Four and Five, but in an order that differs considerably from the Masoretic Text, mixed with other compositions (among them a "Plea for Deliverance," an "Apostrophe to Zion," a "Hymn to the Creator," and a prose note crediting David with 4,050 songs). Scholars debate whether it is a liturgical collection or evidence that the order of the last third of the Psalter was still fluid. The CJT follows the Masoretic order. Near its end the scroll also has a Hebrew form of Psalm 151, which the Septuagint includes as a short autobiographical psalm of David "outside the number" of the 150; it will be translated in the CJT's Apocrypha.

Proverbs

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The proverbs[a] of Solomon[b] son of David,[c] king of Israel:[d]
2 for gaining wisdom and discipline,
for grasping words of insight;
3 for taking in the discipline of good sense,
righteousness, justice, and fairness;
4 for giving shrewdness to the naive,
knowledge and discretion to the young.
5 The wise who hear will increase in learning,
and the discerning will acquire skill in steering,
6 for understanding a proverb and a figure,
the words of the wise and their riddles.
7 The fear of Yahweh is where knowledge begins;[e]
wisdom and discipline the foolish scorn.[f]
8 Listen, my son, to your father's discipline,
and do not abandon your mother's teaching,[g]
9 for they will be a lovely garland on your head
and a pendant around your neck.
10 My son, if sinners entice you,
do not give in.
11 If they urge, "Come with us,
let us hide and wait to shed blood,
let us trap the blameless for no cause;
12 like Sheol,[h] let us gulp them down alive,
entire, like those descending to the Pit;
13 we will find all kinds of precious goods
and fill our houses with plunder.
14 Cast your lot in among us;
one money bag for us all";

15 my son, never travel the road with them;
keep your feet off their trail,
16 for their feet run to evil
and hurry to shed blood.
17 For in vain a net is spread out
while any winged creature is watching![i]
18 Yet these men lie in wait for their own blood;
they ambush their own lives.
19 Such are the ways of everyone greedy for gain:
it takes away the life of those who possess it.
20 Wisdom[j] shouts in the open air;
in the public squares she lifts her voice.
21 At the head of the noisy streets she calls out;
at the openings of the city gates she makes her speech:
22 "How long, you naive ones, will you love naivety,
and mockers delight in mocking,
and fools hate knowledge?
23 Turn around at my reproof!
See, I will let my spirit gush out to you;
I will teach you my words.
24 Because I called and you refused,
I stretched out my hand and no one paid attention,
25 because you brushed aside all my advice
and wanted nothing of my reproof,
26 I in turn will laugh at your disaster;
I will mock when dread comes on you,
27 when dread comes on you like a storm
and your disaster sweeps in like a whirlwind,
when distress and anguish come on you.
28 Then they will call me, but I will not answer;
they will look hard for me but not find me.
29 Because they hated knowledge
and did not choose the fear of Yahweh,

30 would have none of my counsel,
and spurned all my rebuke,
31 they will eat the fruit of their own way
and be glutted with their own schemes.
32 For the waywardness of the naive kills them,
and the ease of fools ruins them.
33 But whoever listens to me will live secure,
at ease, without dread of harm."

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew mishle, plural of mashal, a word covering proverbs, sayings, comparisons, and parables.
- b (1:1) Solomon, Hebrew Shelomoh, related to shalom, "peace."
- c (1:1) David, "beloved."
- d (1:1) Israel, "he strives with God" (Genesis 32:28).
- e (1:7) Or "the first and chief part."
- f (1:7) The Septuagint adds "and there is good understanding for all who practice it, and reverence toward God is the beginning of perception" (compare Psalm 111:10).
- g (1:8) Hebrew torah, "teaching" or "instruction," the word later used for the Law.
- h (1:12) The realm of the dead; also "the Pit" in the next line.
- i (1:17) The meaning may be that a bird is not fooled by a trap set in plain view, unlike these men; or that the bird, seeing only the bait, flies into it anyway.
- j (1:20) Here Wisdom (Hebrew chokhmoth, a plural form) appears as a woman calling in public, a portrait developed in chapters 8–9, where she is set opposite the "foreign woman" and Folly. The figure is often called Lady Wisdom.

Chapter 2

1 My son, if you take in my words
and store up my commands within you,
2 tuning your ear to wisdom,
bending your heart toward understanding;
3 yes, if you call out for insight
and lift up your voice for understanding,
4 if you seek her like silver
and hunt for her as for hidden treasure,
5 then you will understand the fear of Yahweh
and find the knowledge of God.

6 For Yahweh is the giver of wisdom;
knowledge and understanding are the words of his mouth.
7 He stores up sound wisdom[a] for the upright;
he is a shield to those whose walk is blameless,
8 keeping watch over the tracks of justice
and protecting the road of his faithful ones.[b]
9 Then you will understand righteousness and justice
and fairness, every good track.
10 When wisdom enters your heart
and knowledge becomes a delight to your soul,
11 Discretion will keep watch over you;
understanding will stand guard over you,
12 rescuing you from the way of evil,
from men who speak perversely,
13 who leave the straight paths
to walk in the ways of darkness,
14 who delight in doing wrong
and revel in the perversity of evil,
15 whose paths are twisted
and whose tracks are crooked;
16 rescuing you also from the strange woman,[c]
from the foreign woman with her smooth talk,
17 who has left the companion of her youth
and forgotten the covenant of her God.[d]
18 For her house sinks down to death,[e]
and her paths lead to the shades of the dead.[f]
19 All who go in to her never return;
they do not reach the paths of life again.
20 Therefore follow the road of the good
and stay on the tracks of the righteous.
21 For the upright will dwell in the land,
and the blameless will remain in it,
22 but the wicked will be cut off from the land,
and the treacherous will be torn out of it.

Notes

- a (2:7) Hebrew tushiyyah, “sound judgment” or “success.”
- b (2:8) Hebrew chasidim, those loyal to the covenant.
- c (2:16) Hebrew zarah, “strange” or “outsider,” and in the next line nokhriyyah, “foreign”; in Proverbs these words describe another man’s wife, an adulteress. She appears again in 5:3–20; 6:24–35; 7:5–27.
- d (2:17) Or “the covenant made before her God,” that is, her marriage vow.
- e (2:18) Or “For she sinks down to death; her house…”; the Hebrew is difficult.
- f (2:18) Hebrew repha’im, the shades, the dead in Sheol.

Chapter 3

1 My son, do not forget my teaching;
  let your heart keep my commands,
2 for they will add to you length of days,
  years of life, and well-being.
3 Never let steadfast love and truth abandon you;
  bind them around your throat;
  engrave them on your heart’s tablet.
4 Then you will earn favor and a good name
  before God and before people.
5 Trust in Yahweh with your whole heart,
  and do not lean on your own understanding.
6 Acknowledge him in every path you take,
  and he will smooth out your roads.
7 Do not be wise in your own sight;
  fear Yahweh and turn from evil.
8 It will be healing for your navel[a]
  and refreshment[b] for your bones.
9 Give honor to Yahweh out of your riches
  and out of the firstfruits of all your produce;
10 then your barns will be filled with plenty,
  and your vats will burst with new wine.
11 My son, do not reject Yahweh’s discipline,
  and do not resent his correction,
12 for Yahweh corrects the one he loves,
  as a father the son in whom he delights.[c]

13 Happy is the person who finds wisdom,
the person who gains understanding,
14 for her profit is better than profit from silver,
and her yield than fine gold.
15 She is more precious than corals;[d]
nothing you desire can compare with her.
16 Long life is in her right hand;
in her left hand are riches and honor.[e]
17 Her ways are ways of delight,
and all her paths are peace.
18 She is a tree of life for all who seize her,
and whoever holds her tightly is blessed.
19 Yahweh by wisdom founded the earth;
by understanding he set the heavens in place.
20 By his knowledge the depths burst open,
and the clouds drip down dew.
21 My son, do not let them slip from your sight;
keep sound wisdom and discretion.
22 They will be life to your soul
and an ornament at your throat.
23 Then you will go your way safely,
and your foot will not trip.
24 When you lie down, you will have no fear;
you will lie down, and your sleep will be sweet.[f]
25 Do not fear sudden terror
or the ruin of the wicked when it comes,
26 for Yahweh will be your confidence
and will keep your foot from the snare.
27 Do not withhold good from those to whom it is due,
when it is in your power to act.
28 Do not tell your neighbor, “Go away, come back later,
tomorrow I will give it,” when it is right there with you.
29 Do not devise evil against your neighbor
when he lives in trust beside you.

30 Do not quarrel with anyone for no reason
when he has done you no harm.
31 Do not be jealous of a man of violence,
and do not choose a single one of his ways,
32 for the devious are detestable to Yahweh,
but the upright are in his confidence.
33 Yahweh's curse is on the house of the wicked,
but he blesses the home of the righteous.
34 Toward mockers he is a mocker,
but to the humble he shows favor.[g]
35 The wise will inherit honor,
but fools carry off disgrace.[h]

Notes

- a (3:8) Or "your body"; the Septuagint reads "your body."
- b (3:8) Literally "drink" or "moistening."
- c (3:12) The Septuagint reads "and he scourges every son whom he receives," the form quoted in Hebrews 12:6.
- d (3:15) Or "rubies" or "pearls"; the exact gem is uncertain.
- e (3:16) The Septuagint adds "Out of her mouth comes righteousness, and she carries law and mercy on her tongue."
- f (3:24) The Septuagint reads "If you rest, you will be unafraid; if you sleep, you will sleep sweetly."
- g (3:34) The Septuagint reads "The Lord opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble" (Greek kyrios, its usual rendering of Yahweh), the form quoted in James 4:6 and 1 Peter 5:5.
- h (3:35) Or "but fools exalt disgrace"; the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 4

1 Listen, children, to a father's discipline;
pay attention so as to learn understanding.
2 It is sound learning I hand on to you;
do not walk away from my instruction.
3 I too was once a boy in my father's house,
young and tender, my mother's only one,
4 he taught me and said to me,
"Let your heart hold fast to my words;
keep my commands and live.

5 Get wisdom, get understanding;
do not forget, do not swerve from the words of my mouth.
6 Do not leave her, and she will guard you;
love her, and she will keep you safe.
7 The beginning of wisdom is: get wisdom!
With all you have gotten, get understanding.[a]
8 Prize her, and she will lift you high;
she will bring you honor if you embrace her.
9 She will set a graceful garland on your head;
a crown of splendor she will hand to you."
10 Listen, my son, and take in what I say,
so that your life will last many years.
11 I have taught you the way of wisdom;
I have led you along upright tracks.
12 As you walk, your steps will meet no obstacle,
and when you run, you will not trip.
13 Seize hold of discipline and never loosen your grip;
protect her, since she is your very life.
14 Do not set foot on the path of the wicked,
and do not stride along the way of evildoers.
15 Avoid it, do not cross over to it;
turn away from it and pass on.
16 For they cannot sleep unless they have done wrong;
their sleep is snatched away unless they have tripped someone up.
17 For they eat the bread of wickedness
and drink the wine of violence.
18 The road of the righteous is like first light at daybreak,
glowing ever stronger until the day is full.
19 The road of the wicked is like thick gloom;
they cannot tell what trips them up.
20 My son, attend to my words;
bend your ear to my sayings.
21 Do not let them slip from your eyes;
keep them in the center of your heart.

22 For they are life to those who find them
and healing to all their flesh.
23 More than anything you guard, guard your heart,
for from it flow the springs of life.
24 Put crooked speech away from you;
keep devious lips far from you.
25 Let your eyes look straight ahead,
your gaze be fixed directly before you.
26 Make a level path for your feet to travel,
and every road you take will hold firm.
27 Lean neither right nor left;
keep your foot back from evil.[b]

Notes

- a (4:7) This verse is not in the Septuagint.
- b (4:27) The Septuagint adds "For God knows the ways on the right, but those on the left are crooked; and he will make your ways straight and guide your steps in peace."

Chapter 5

1 My son, attend to my wisdom;
bend your ear to my understanding,
2 so that discretion stays with you
and your lips preserve knowledge.
3 For the lips of the strange woman drip honey,
and her palate is smoother than oil,
4 but in the end she is bitter as wormwood,[a]
sharp as a two-edged sword.
5 Her feet go down to death;
her steps take hold of Sheol.
6 She does not keep straight on the path of life;
her tracks wander, and she does not know it.[b]
7 So now, children, listen to me,
and do not turn aside from the words of my mouth.
8 Keep your path well away from her;
stay clear of the entrance to her house,

9 lest you hand over your prime to other men
and your years to a merciless one;
10 strangers will feast on your strength,
and your labors will go to a foreigner's house.
11 You will moan when your end comes,
when your flesh and your body are wasted,
12 and you will say, "Oh, how I loathed discipline!
How my heart despised reproof!
13 I would not listen to the voice of my teachers
or bend my ear to my instructors.
14 I came close to utter ruin
in the midst of the assembly and congregation."
15 Draw your water from a cistern that is yours,
running water out of a well that is yours.[c]
16 Must your springs spill out into the streets,
your channels of water into the squares?
17 Let them be yours alone,
not shared with strangers.
18 May your fountain be blessed,
and rejoice in the wife of your youth,
19 a lovely doe, a graceful ibex.
May her breasts fill you with delight forever;
be captivated always by her love.
20 Why should you be intoxicated, my son, with a strange woman
and embrace the bosom of a foreigner?
21 For a man's ways are in full view of Yahweh,
and he weighs[d] all his paths.
22 The wicked man's own iniquities will trap him;
he will be held fast in the cords of his sin.
23 He will die for lack of discipline,
and through the greatness of his folly he will stagger away.[e]

Notes

- a (5:4) Wormwood, a plant with a very bitter taste, a byword for bitterness.
- b (5:6) Or "so that you do not walk the level path of life; her tracks wander, and you do not know it."

- c (5:15) In verses 15–18 water, cistern, and fountain are images of the man's own wife.
- d (5:21) Or "levels."
- e (5:23) The Hebrew word for "stagger" is the same as "be intoxicated" in verses 19–20.

Chapter 6

1 My son, if you have stood surety for your neighbor,
  have struck hands in pledge for a stranger,
2 if you are snared by the words of your mouth,
  caught by what your own lips have said,
3 then do this, my son, and get yourself free,
  since you have fallen into your neighbor's hand:
  go, humble yourself,[a] and pester your neighbor.
4 Do not let your eyes close in sleep
  or your eyelids droop.
5 Tear yourself loose like a gazelle from the hunter's grip,[b]
  like a bird from the fowler's hand.
6 Go to the ant, you lazybones;
  watch her ways and grow wise.
7 She has no commander,
  no overseer or ruler,
8 yet she lays in her food in summer
  and gathers her provisions at harvest.[c]
9 How long will you lie there, lazybones?
  When will you get up from your sleep?
10 A little sleep, a little dozing,
  a little folding of the hands to rest,
11 and poverty will come on you like a prowler,
  and want like an armed man.[d]
12 A good-for-nothing,[e] a man of iniquity,
  walks around with crooked speech,
13 winking with his eyes, signaling with his feet,
  pointing with his fingers.
14 Perversity is in his heart; he devises evil all the time;
  he lets loose quarrels.

15 Therefore disaster will come on him suddenly;
in an instant he will be broken beyond healing.
16 There are six things Yahweh hates,
seven that are detestable to him:[f]
17 haughty eyes, a lying tongue,
hands that shed innocent blood,
18 a heart that devises wicked schemes,
feet quick to run to evil,
19 a lying witness who puffs out falsehoods,
and one who stirs up strife between brothers.
20 My son, keep your father's command,
and do not abandon your mother's teaching.
21 Fasten them to your heart forever;
knot them about your throat.
22 When you walk, it will lead you;
when you lie down, it will watch over you;
when you wake, it will talk with you.
23 For the command is a lamp, the teaching is light,
and correction that disciplines is the road to life,
24 keeping you from the wicked woman,[g]
from the slick tongue of the outsider.
25 Do not let your heart crave her loveliness,
and do not be taken in by the flutter of her lashes.
26 For a prostitute's price is a round of bread,
but another man's wife stalks a man's very life.[h]
27 Can a man scoop fire into his lap
and his clothes not be burned?
28 Or can one walk on hot coals
and his feet not be scorched?
29 So it is with one who goes in to his neighbor's wife;
no one who touches her will go unpunished.
30 People do not despise a thief if he steals
to fill his belly when he is hungry;

31 yet if caught, he must repay sevenfold;
he must give up all the goods of his house.
32 The man who commits adultery has no sense;
he who does so brings ruin on himself.
33 Blows and dishonor he will get,
and his disgrace will not be wiped away.
34 For jealousy kindles a husband's rage;
on the day of vengeance he will not spare.
35 He will accept no compensation;
he will not be appeased though you multiply gifts.

Notes

- a (6:3) Or "trample yourself," that is, swallow your pride.
- b (6:5) Literally "from the hand"; "of the hunter" is supplied from the parallel line, as in some ancient witnesses.
- c (6:8) The Septuagint adds "Or go to the bee and learn how diligent she is and how earnest her work is; kings and commoners use her labors for health, and she is desired and honored by all; though weak in strength, she is advanced because she honors wisdom."
- d (6:11) The Septuagint adds "But if you are diligent, your harvest will come like a spring, and poverty will run away like a poor runner."
- e (6:12) Hebrew 'adam beliyya'al, "a man of Belial," a word for worthlessness or wickedness.
- f (6:16) A "six… seven" saying, a numerical pattern also found in 30:15–31.
- g (6:24) The Septuagint reads "from the married woman."
- h (6:26) Or "For on account of a prostitute a man is brought to a loaf of bread." The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.

Chapter 7

1 My son, keep my words
and treasure up my commands within you.[a]
2 Keep my commands and live,
my teaching like the pupil of your eye.
3 Tie them on your fingers;
inscribe them on the tablet of your heart.
4 Say to wisdom, "You are my sister,"
and call understanding your kinswoman,

5 to keep you from the strange woman,
from the foreign woman with her smooth words.
6 From the window of my house
I looked out through my lattice,
7 and I saw among the naive,
I noticed among the youths,
a young man lacking sense,
8 passing along the street near her corner,
taking the road toward her house,
9 in the twilight, in the evening of the day,
in the dead of night and the dark.
10 And there a woman comes to meet him,
dressed like a prostitute, with a guarded heart.[b]
11 She is loud and unruly;
her feet never stay at home;
12 one moment out in the road, the next in the market squares,
at every street corner she waits in ambush.
13 She seizes him and kisses him;
boldfaced, she tells him,
14 "I had to offer peace offerings;
today I have paid my vows.[c]
15 So I have come out on purpose to meet you,
searching for your face, and here you are!
16 I have spread my couch with coverings,
colored linens from Egypt.
17 I have sprinkled my bed
with myrrh, aloes, and cinnamon.
18 Come, let us soak ourselves in lovemaking till dawn;
let us revel in love.
19 For my husband is not at home;
he has gone on a long journey.
20 He took a bag of money with him;
he will come home at the full moon."

21 With her many persuasions she bends him;
with her smooth lips she drives him on.
22 All at once he follows her,
like an ox going to the slaughter,
like a fool to the stocks for punishment,[d]
23 until an arrow pierces his liver,
like a bird rushing into a snare,
not knowing it will cost him his life.
24 So now, children, listen to me;
pay attention to the words of my mouth.
25 Let your heart not veer toward her roads;
do not stray onto her tracks,
26 for many are the victims she has brought down,
and countless are all those she has slain.
27 Her house is the way to Sheol,
going down to the chambers of death.

Notes

- a (7:1) The Septuagint adds a couplet: "My son, honor the Lord and you will be strong; and fear no one else besides him."
- b (7:10) Or "with secret intent" or "with a veiled heart."
- c (7:14) The meat of a peace offering had to be eaten within a day or two (Leviticus 7:15–16), so she has a feast ready.
- d (7:22) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain; the Septuagint reads "as a dog to bonds, or as a deer shot in the liver with an arrow."

Chapter 8

1 Listen! Is that not Wisdom calling,
Understanding lifting up her voice?[a]
2 On the heights beside the road,
where the paths meet, she takes her stand;
3 beside the gates at the entrance to the city,
at the doorways she cries aloud:
4 "To you, people, I am calling;
my voice goes out to all humankind.
5 You naive, learn shrewdness;
you fools, learn sense.[b]

6 Listen, for I speak of noble things;
from my lips come upright words.
7 My mouth utters truth;
wickedness is detestable to my lips.
8 All the words of my mouth are in righteousness;
nothing in them is twisted or crooked.
9 They are all plain to the discerning
and right to those who find knowledge.
10 Take my discipline instead of silver,
knowledge rather than choice gold,
11 for wisdom is better than corals,
and nothing desirable can equal her.
12 I, Wisdom, live with shrewdness;
I find out knowledge and discretion.
13 To fear Yahweh is to hate evil.
Pride and arrogance, the way of evil,
and a perverse mouth I hate.
14 Counsel and sound wisdom are mine;
I am understanding; strength is mine.
15 Through me kings hold their thrones
and rulers enact just laws.
16 By me princes govern,
and nobles, all who judge rightly.[c]
17 Those who love me I love,
and those who seek me early will find me.
18 Riches and honor are with me,
enduring wealth and righteousness.
19 My fruit is better than gold, than pure gold,
and my yield than choice silver.
20 In the road of righteousness I go,
in the middle of the tracks of justice,
21 to endow with wealth those who love me
and to fill their treasuries.[d]

22 Yahweh acquired me[e] at the beginning of his way,
before his works of long ago.
23 From everlasting I was set up,[f]
from the first, before the earth began.
24 When there were no depths I was brought forth,
when there were no springs heavy with water.
25 Before the mountains were sunk in place,
before the hills, I was brought forth,
26 while he had not yet made the earth and the open fields
or the first of the dust of the world.
27 When he fixed the skies in place, I was present,
when he marked out a circle over the surface of the deep,
28 when he made firm the clouds above,
when the springs of the deep grew strong,
29 when he assigned the sea its limit
so that the waters would not pass his command,
when he marked out the foundations of the earth,
30 then I was at his side as a master craftsman,[g]
and I was his joy every day,
laughing and playing in his presence always,
31 laughing over the world, his earth,
and finding my joy among humankind.
32 Now then, children, hear me:
blessed are those who keep to my ways.
33 Listen to discipline and be wise;
do not neglect it.
34 Blessed is the person who hears me,
keeping watch at my gates day by day,
standing guard at my doorposts.
35 For whoever finds me finds life
and obtains favor from Yahweh,
36 but whoever fails to find me wrongs his own soul;[h]
all who hate me are in love with death."

Notes

- a (8:1) Wisdom speaks in her own voice through this chapter. On the figure of Lady Wisdom, see the note at 1:20.
- b (8:5) Literally "understand heart."
- c (8:16) Literally "all the judges of righteousness"; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "the earth."
- d (8:21) The Septuagint adds "If I tell you what happens daily, I will remember to recount the things of old."
- e (8:22) Hebrew qanani, from qanah, which usually means "acquire," "get," or "possess" (as in 4:5, 7), and in a few places may mean "create" or "beget" (Genesis 14:19, 22; Deuteronomy 32:6). The Septuagint has ektisen, "created" (Brenton "made"); Aquila and other later Greek versions have "acquired" or "possessed." The verse became central in the fourth-century debates over the nature of Christ, identified with Wisdom.
- f (8:23) Or "woven," as in Psalm 139:13, or "installed."
- g (8:30) Hebrew 'amon; or "like a little child," reading 'amun, "nursling." The Septuagint has "suiting myself to him."
- h (8:36) Or "whoever sins against me."

Chapter 9

1 Wisdom has built her house;
  she has hewn out her seven pillars.[a]
2 She has slaughtered her animals, mixed her wine,
  and set her table.
3 She has sent out her young women; she calls
  from the highest points of the city:
4 "Whoever is naive, turn in here!"
  To the one lacking sense she says,
5 "Come, eat of my bread
  and drink of the wine I have mixed.
6 Leave naivety behind and live;
  walk straight on in the way of understanding."
7 Whoever corrects a mocker earns abuse;
  whoever rebukes a wicked man gets hurt.
8 Do not rebuke a mocker, or he will hate you;
  rebuke a wise man, and he will love you.
9 Instruct the wise, and they grow wiser still;
  teach the righteous, and they add to their learning.

10 The fear of Yahweh is the start of wisdom,
and knowledge of the Holy One[b] is understanding.[c]
11 For through me your days will multiply,
and years of life will be added to you.
12 If you are wise, you are wise to your own benefit;
if you mock, you alone will bear it.[d]
13 Lady Folly is boisterous,
naive, and knows nothing at all.[e]
14 She sits at the door of her house,
on a seat at the heights of the city,
15 hailing the passers-by
who are keeping to the straight road:
16 "Whoever is naive, turn in here!"
To the one lacking sense she says,
17 "Stolen water is sweet,
and bread eaten in secret is delicious."
18 But he does not know that the shades are there,
that her guests are in the depths of Sheol.[f]

Notes

- a (9:1) The seven pillars may picture a grand house, the seven days of creation, or the completeness of Wisdom's work; the meaning is debated.
- b (9:10) Hebrew qedoshim, plural, perhaps a plural of majesty; or "of holy ones."
- c (9:10) The Septuagint adds "for to know the law is the mark of a sound mind."
- d (9:12) The Septuagint adds three verses comparing the one who leans on lies to someone who herds the winds and chases birds in flight, abandons his own vineyard, and walks through a dry desert gathering barrenness with his hands.
- e (9:13) Literally "A woman of folly." Folly is drawn as Wisdom's rival, inviting the same naive guests (compare verses 4 and 16). The second line is uncertain; the Septuagint reads "and she does not know shame."
- f (9:18) The Septuagint adds "But hurry away; do not linger in the place or fix your eye on her, for so you will pass through strange water. Keep away from strange water, and do not drink from a strange fountain, so that you may live long and years of life may be added to you."

Chapter 10

1 The proverbs of Solomon.[a]
A wise son makes his father glad,
but a foolish son is his mother's sorrow.
2 Treasures gained by wickedness bring no profit,
but righteousness rescues from death.
3 Yahweh will not let the righteous go hungry,
but he pushes away the craving of the wicked.
4 Lazy hands lead to poverty,
but hard-working hands bring wealth.[b]
5 A son who gathers in summer acts wisely;
a son who sleeps through harvest brings shame.
6 Blessings rest on the head of the righteous,
but the mouth of the wicked hides violence.[c]
7 To remember the righteous is to bless them,
but the name of the wicked decays.
8 The wise of heart takes commands to heart,
but a babbling fool will be thrown down.
9 Whoever walks in integrity walks securely,
but whoever twists his ways will be found out.
10 One who winks the eye causes grief,
and a babbling fool will be thrown down.[d]
11 The mouth of the righteous is a fountain of life,
but the mouth of the wicked hides violence.
12 Hatred stirs up quarrels,
but love throws a covering over every offense.
13 Wisdom is found on the lips of the discerning,
but a rod is for the back of the one without sense.
14 The wise store up knowledge,
but the mouth of a fool brings ruin near.
15 The wealth of the rich is their fortified city;
the ruin of the poor is their poverty.
16 The wages of the righteous lead to life,
the income of the wicked to sin.

17 One who heeds discipline is on the path to life,
but one who ignores correction leads others astray.
18 Lips that cover up hatred are liars,
and the one who puts out slander is a fool.
19 When words are many, wrongdoing is not lacking,
but the one who holds back his lips is prudent.
20 The tongue of the righteous is choice silver;
the heart of the wicked is worth little.
21 The lips of the righteous feed many,
but fools die for lack of sense.
22 Yahweh's blessing is what makes rich,
and toil adds nothing to it.[e]
23 Doing wrong is like a game to a fool,
and wisdom is the same to a man of understanding.
24 The thing the wicked man fears overtakes him;
the longing of the righteous is granted.
25 Once the tempest sweeps by, the wicked vanish,
but the righteous are rooted for all time.
26 Like vinegar to the teeth and smoke to the eyes
is the sluggard to those who send him.
27 The fear of Yahweh lengthens days,
but the years of the wicked will be cut short.
28 The hope of the righteous ends in joy,
but the expectation of the wicked comes to nothing.
29 The way of Yahweh is a stronghold for the blameless,
but ruin for those who do evil.
30 Forever the righteous stays unmoved;
the wicked will not live on in the land.
31 The righteous person's mouth yields wise fruit,
but a twisted tongue will be chopped off.
32 The righteous person's lips know what is fitting,
but the wicked person's mouth knows only crookedness.

Notes

- a (10:1) Chapters 10:1–22:16 are a collection of mostly two-line sayings, 375 in number, the numerical value of the Hebrew letters in the name Solomon (shlmh).

- b (10:4) The Septuagint adds “A son who is instructed will be wise and will use the fool as a servant.”
- c (10:6) Or “but violence covers the mouth of the wicked”; the same line recurs in verse 11.
- d (10:10) The second line repeats verse 8b; the Septuagint reads “but one who reproves boldly makes peace.”
- e (10:22) Or “and he adds no sorrow with it.”

Chapter 11

1 False scales are detestable to Yahweh,
but an honest weight is his delight.[a]
2 When pride comes, disgrace comes too,
but with the humble is wisdom.
3 The upright are led by their own wholeness;
the treacherous are ruined by their own twisting.
4 Wealth is no help on the day of wrath,
but righteousness rescues from death.[b]
5 The righteousness of the blameless makes his road straight,
but the wicked falls by his own wickedness.
6 Their righteousness sets the upright free,
while traitors are trapped by their greed.
7 When a wicked man dies, his hope perishes,
and the expectation of strength is lost.[c]
8 The righteous is rescued from trouble,
and the wicked comes in his place.
9 With his mouth the godless destroys his neighbor,
but by knowledge the righteous are rescued.
10 When the righteous prosper, the city rejoices,
and when the wicked perish, there are shouts of joy.
11 By the blessing of the upright a city is raised high,
but by the mouth of the wicked it is torn down.
12 To look down on a neighbor is senseless;
a discerning person holds his tongue.
13 A gossip goes around revealing secrets,
but the trustworthy in spirit keeps a matter covered.

14 Without guidance a people falls,
but with many counselors there is victory.
15 Whoever pledges for a stranger will suffer harm,
but whoever hates handshake pledges is secure.
16 A gracious woman gains honor,
and ruthless men gain riches.[d]
17 A kind man does good to himself,
but a cruel one harms his own flesh.
18 The wicked person's wages are a mirage,
but whoever plants righteousness reaps a sure reward.
19 Steadfast righteousness leads to life,
but whoever pursues evil goes to his death.
20 The crooked of heart are detestable to Yahweh,
but those whose way is blameless are his delight.
21 Be sure of it: the evildoer will not go unpunished,
but the offspring of the righteous will escape.
22 A gold ring in a pig's snout—
so is a beautiful woman who has turned from good sense.
23 What the righteous long for is only good;
what the wicked can expect is wrath.
24 One gives freely and grows richer;
another holds back more than is right and ends in want.
25 The person who blesses others will grow fat,
and the one who gives drink will be given drink.
26 People curse the one who hoards grain,
but blessing crowns the head of the one who sells it.
27 The one who looks hard for good is looking for favor;
the one who hunts for evil, it will find him.
28 Whoever trusts in his riches will fall,
but the righteous will flourish like green leaves.
29 A man who brings trouble on his own house will be left holding the wind,
and the fool ends up slave to the wise.

30 The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life,
and a wise person wins lives.[e]
31 If on earth the righteous get their due,
all the more the wicked and the sinner![f]

Notes

- a (11:1) Literally “a full stone”; weights were stones carried in a merchant’s bag.
- b (11:4) The Septuagint lacks this verse.
- c (11:7) Or “of wealth”; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (11:16) The Septuagint expands this verse: “A gracious wife brings glory to her husband, but a woman who hates righteousness is a seat of dishonor. The lazy come to want, but the diligent hold on to wealth.”
- e (11:30) Or “takes lives.” The Septuagint reads “but the lives of transgressors are cut off before their time.”
- f (11:31) The Septuagint reads “If the righteous are scarcely saved, where will the ungodly and the sinner appear?” quoted in 1 Peter 4:18.

Chapter 12

1 To love correction is to love knowledge;
to hate reproof is brutish.
2 A good person obtains favor from Yahweh,
but a man of schemes he condemns.
3 No one is made secure by wickedness,
but the root of the righteous will not be moved.
4 A woman of strength is her husband’s crown,
but one who shames him is like rot in his bones.
5 The plans of the righteous are just;
the guidance of the wicked is deceit.
6 The words of the wicked lie in wait for blood,
but the mouth of the upright rescues them.
7 Overthrow the wicked and they are no more,
but the house of the righteous will stand.
8 A man is praised according to his good sense,
but one with a twisted mind is despised.
9 Better a nobody with a servant
than a self-important man with no bread.

10 The righteous knows the needs of his animals,
but the compassion of the wicked is cruel.
11 Whoever works his land will have plenty of bread,
but whoever chases worthless things lacks sense.[a]
12 The wicked covets the catch of evildoers,
but the root of the righteous yields fruit.[b]
13 In the offense of the lips is an evil snare,
but the righteous escapes from trouble.[c]
14 From the fruit of his mouth a person is filled with good,
and the work of his hands comes back to him.
15 The way of a fool is right in his own eyes,
but the wise listens to advice.
16 A fool shows his anger at once,
but the shrewd ignores an insult.
17 A truthful witness declares what is just,
and a lying witness, what deceives.
18 Some speak rashly, like the thrusts of a sword,
but the tongue of the wise brings healing.
19 Truthful lips endure forever,
but a lying tongue lasts only a moment.
20 Treachery lives in the heart of evil schemers,
while counselors of peace are glad.
21 No harm befalls the righteous,
but the wicked are filled with trouble.
22 Lying lips are detestable to Yahweh,
but those who act faithfully are his delight.
23 A shrewd man conceals knowledge,
but the heart of fools proclaims folly.
24 Diligent hands will govern,
but laziness ends in forced labor.
25 Worry in the heart bows a man down,
and a kind word cheers him.
26 The righteous guides his neighbor,[d]
but the way of the wicked leads them astray.

27 The lazy man does not roast his game,
but a diligent man gains precious wealth.[e]
28 In the path of righteousness is life,
and along its way there is no death.[f]

Notes

- a (12:11) The Septuagint adds "Whoever enjoys himself at banquets of wine will leave dishonor in his strongholds."
- b (12:12) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- c (12:13) The Septuagint adds "One whose looks are gentle will be pitied, but one who quarrels at the gates afflicts souls."
- d (12:26) Or "The righteous searches out his pasture"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (12:27) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- f (12:28) Or "but the way of a path leads to death," with some ancient witnesses.

Chapter 13

1 A wise son heeds his father's discipline,
but a mocker does not listen to rebuke.
2 From the fruit of his mouth a person eats good things,
but the appetite of the treacherous is for violence.
3 Whoever guards his mouth preserves his life;
whoever opens wide his lips comes to ruin.
4 The sluggard craves and gets nothing,
but the appetite of the diligent is richly satisfied.
5 The righteous hates a lie,
but the wicked brings stench and shame.
6 Righteousness keeps watch over a blameless road,
and wickedness brings the sinner down.[a]
7 Some put on a show of wealth and own nothing;
some put on a show of poverty and own a fortune.
8 A man's riches may ransom his life,
but the poor hears no threat.
9 The light of the righteous shines brightly,
but the lamp of the wicked will be snuffed out.[b]
10 Arrogance yields nothing but quarrels,
while the well-advised have wisdom.

11 Money from vanity shrinks away;
  money gathered by hand grows.
12 Long-delayed hope sickens the heart;
  a longing that comes true is a tree of life.
13 Whoever despises a word will pay for it,
  but whoever fears a command will be rewarded.[c]
14 The teaching of the wise is a fountain of life,
  for turning away from the snares of death.
15 Good judgment earns goodwill,
  but the path of the faithless leads to destruction.[d]
16 Every shrewd person acts with knowledge,
  but a fool spreads out his folly.
17 A wicked messenger falls into trouble,
  but a faithful envoy brings healing.
18 Poverty and disgrace come to the one who ignores discipline,
  but whoever heeds correction is honored.
19 Desire fulfilled is sweet to the soul,
  but turning from evil is detestable to fools.
20 Walk with the wise and become wise,
  but the companion of fools will suffer harm.
21 Disaster pursues sinners,
  but the righteous are repaid with good.
22 The good leave something for their children's children;
  the sinner's goods are laid up for the just.
23 The new-broken fields of the poor can grow plenty to eat,
  yet some are swept away for want of justice.[e]
24 Whoever spares his rod hates his son,
  but whoever loves him is diligent to discipline him.
25 The righteous eat until they are satisfied,
  but the stomach of the wicked is left empty.

Notes

- a (13:6) The Septuagint lacks this verse.
- b (13:9) The Septuagint adds "Deceitful souls go astray in sins, but the righteous show pity and mercy."

- c (13:13) The Septuagint adds “A deceitful son will have nothing good, but a wise servant will prosper, and his way will be made straight.”
- d (13:15) Or “is enduring”; the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads “is in destruction.”
- e (13:23) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.

Chapter 14

1 Wise women build up their houses,[a]
but Folly tears hers down with her own hands.
2 A man who walks uprightly fears Yahweh;
a man crooked in his ways despises him.
3 In the fool’s mouth is a rod for his pride,[b]
but the lips of the wise keep them safe.
4 Where there are no oxen, the manger stays clean,
but an ox’s strength brings in a large harvest.
5 An honest witness does not lie,
but a false witness pours out lies.
6 The scoffer looks for wisdom and never finds it,
but to the discerning, knowledge comes easily.
7 Get away from the presence of a fool;
you will not meet knowing lips there.
8 The wisdom of the shrewd is to understand his road,
but the folly of fools is deceit.
9 Fools make a joke of guilt,[c]
but among the upright there is goodwill.
10 Only the heart knows its bitter places,
and in its gladness no outsider has a share.
11 The house of the wicked will be wiped out,
but the tent of the upright will flourish.
12 There is a road that looks straight to a man,
but at its end are the roads of death.
13 A heart can hurt while it laughs,
and joy may finish in sorrow.
14 The backslider gets his fill of his own ways,
and a good man, of what is his.[d]

15 The naive believes every word,
but the shrewd watches his steps.
16 The wise is cautious and turns away from evil,
but the fool is reckless and sure of himself.
17 The quick-tempered does foolish things,
and a schemer is hated.
18 The naive inherit folly,
but the shrewd are crowned with knowledge.
19 The evil bow down before the good,
and the wicked at the gates of the righteous.
20 The poor man is disliked even by his neighbor,
but the rich have friends by the dozen.
21 Whoever despises his neighbor sins,
but happy is the one who is kind to the poor.
22 Do not those who plot evil go astray?
Those who plan good meet with loyalty and faithfulness.
23 Every kind of toil yields a gain;
talk of the lips brings only lack.
24 The crown of the wise is their riches;
the folly of fools is folly.[e]
25 A witness who tells the truth delivers lives;
a witness who puffs out lies is fraud itself.
26 Fear of Yahweh gives deep security,
and it becomes a shelter for one's children.
27 The fear of Yahweh is a fountain of life,
for turning aside from the snares of death.
28 A king's glory lies in a multitude of people,
but without people a prince is ruined.
29 The patient person has great understanding,
but the quick-tempered puts folly on display.
30 A calm heart gives life to the body,
but envy is rot in the bones.
31 Whoever oppresses the poor insults his Maker,
but whoever is gracious to the needy honors him.

32 The wicked is thrown down by his own evil,
but the righteous finds refuge even in his death.[f]
33 In a discerning heart Wisdom settles down to rest;
inside fools she is made known.[g]
34 Righteousness lifts a nation high,
but sin is a disgrace to any people.
35 The king favors a servant who acts wisely,
but his wrath falls on one who acts shamefully.

Notes

- a (14:1) Or "Wisdom builds her house," reading the plural as an honorific, as in 9:1.
- b (14:3) Or "a shoot of pride."
- c (14:9) Or "Guilt mocks fools." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (14:14) Or "and a good man, from what he does."
- e (14:24) The Septuagint reads "a shrewd man is the crown of the wise, but the occupation of fools is evil."
- f (14:32) Hebrew bemoto. Many interpreters read betummo, "in his integrity," by transposing two letters; the Septuagint has "in his own holiness."
- g (14:33) The Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "but in the heart of fools she is not known."

Chapter 15

1 A gentle answer turns back rage,
but a word that wounds stirs up anger.
2 Knowledge sounds good from a wise tongue;
folly bubbles from the mouths of fools.
3 The eyes of Yahweh are everywhere,
watching the evil and the good.
4 A healing tongue is a tree of life,
but a twisted one crushes the spirit.
5 A fool spurns his father's discipline,
but whoever accepts correction shows good sense.
6 In the house of the righteous there is great treasure,
but trouble comes with the earnings of the wicked.
7 The lips of the wise scatter knowledge,
but not so the heart of fools.

8 The sacrifice of the wicked is detestable to Yahweh,
but the prayer of the upright is his delight.
9 The road of the wicked is loathsome to Yahweh;
the one who chases after righteousness he loves.
10 Harsh discipline awaits the one who leaves the path;
whoever hates correction will die.
11 Sheol and Abaddon[a] lie open before Yahweh;
how much more human hearts!
12 A mocker does not like to be corrected;
he will not go to the wise.
13 A glad heart makes a cheerful face,
but by heartache the spirit is crushed.
14 The discerning heart seeks knowledge,
but the mouth of fools grazes on folly.
15 Every day is a hard day for the poor,
but a good heart feasts without end.
16 Better a little with the fear of Yahweh
than great treasure and turmoil with it.
17 Better a dish of vegetables where there is love
than a fattened ox and hatred with it.
18 A hot-tempered man stirs up conflict,
but one slow to anger calms a quarrel.[b]
19 The way of the sluggard is like a hedge of thorns,
but the path of the upright is a highway.
20 A wise son makes a father glad,
but a foolish man despises his mother.
21 Foolishness pleases the senseless;
the discerning keeps a straight course.
22 Where no one takes counsel, plans come apart;
where advisers are many, they hold.
23 A person finds joy in an apt reply,
and a word in season, how good it is!
24 For the wise the path of life leads upward,
so that he turns away from Sheol below.

25 Yahweh tears down the house of the proud,
but he sets the widow's boundary in place.
26 Evil plans are detestable to Yahweh,
but kind words are pure.
27 A man grasping after profit brings trouble home;
a man who hates a gift will live.[c]
28 The righteous heart thinks before answering,
but the wicked mouth pours out evil.[d]
29 Yahweh is far from the wicked,
but he hears the prayer of the righteous.[e]
30 A twinkle in the eye cheers the heart;
a good report nourishes the body.
31 The ear that listens to life-giving correction
will lodge among the wise.[f]
32 To shrug off discipline is to reject your own life;
to hear reproof is to acquire a heart.
33 Fear of Yahweh trains a person in wisdom,
and lowliness walks ahead of glory.

Notes

- a (15:11) Abaddon, "destruction," is a name for the realm of the dead, paired with Sheol.
- b (15:18) The Septuagint adds "A man slow to anger will put out quarrels, but an ungodly man stirs them up instead."
- c (15:27) The Septuagint adds "By almsgiving and faithful dealing sins are cleansed away, but by the fear of the Lord everyone turns from evil," a form of 16:6.
- d (15:28) The Septuagint adds "The ways of righteous people are acceptable to the Lord, and through them even enemies become friends," a form of 16:7.
- e (15:29) The Septuagint adds "Better a small income with righteousness than abundant produce with unrighteousness. Let a person's heart think rightly, so that his steps may be made straight by God," forms of 16:8–9.
- f (15:31) The Septuagint lacks this verse.

Chapter 16

1 The plans of the heart belong to a person,
but the answer of the tongue comes from Yahweh.[a]
2 All a man's ways are pure in his own eyes,
but Yahweh weighs the spirits.

3 Roll your works onto Yahweh,
and your plans will be established.
4 Yahweh has made everything for its own end,
even the wicked for the day of disaster.
5 Everyone proud of heart is detestable to Yahweh;
be sure of it, he will not go unpunished.
6 Through steadfast love and truth, wrongdoing is covered,
and through fearing Yahweh people steer clear of evil.
7 When Yahweh is pleased with a man's ways,
he makes even his enemies be at peace with him.
8 Better a little with righteousness
than large revenues without justice.
9 A man's heart plans his way,
but Yahweh directs his steps.
10 An oracle is on the lips of a king;
his mouth must not betray justice.
11 Accurate scales and balances are Yahweh's;
every stone weight in the pouch is his doing.
12 Doing evil is detestable to kings,
for a throne is made firm by righteousness.
13 Kings take pleasure in honest lips;
they love a straight talker.
14 A king's wrath is a messenger of death,
but a wise man will appease it.
15 When a king's face is bright, there is life,
and his goodwill is like a rain cloud in spring.
16 Acquiring wisdom is far better than gold!
Choosing insight is worth more than silver.
17 The highway of the upright turns away from evil;
whoever watches his way guards his life.
18 Pride goes before destruction,
and a haughty spirit before a fall.
19 It is better to be lowly in spirit among the humble
than to share spoils with the arrogant.

20 Whoever pays attention to a matter will find good,
and happy is the one who trusts in Yahweh.
21 The wise of heart is called discerning,
and sweet speech adds persuasiveness.
22 Insight is a spring of life to its owner;
folly is the fool's own punishment.
23 The heart of the wise makes his mouth prudent
and adds persuasiveness to his lips.
24 Pleasant words are a honeycomb,
sweet to the soul and healing to the bones.
25 There is a road that looks straight to a man,
but at its end are the roads of death.
26 A laborer's appetite works for him,
for his mouth urges him on.
27 A worthless man digs up evil,
and on his lips it is like a scorching fire.
28 A perverse man spreads strife,
and a whisperer separates close friends.
29 A violent man entices his neighbor
and leads him in a way that is not good.
30 Whoever winks his eyes is plotting perversity;
whoever purses his lips has finished his evil.
31 Gray hair is a crown of glory;
it is found in the way of righteousness.
32 Better one slow to anger than a warrior,
and one who rules his spirit than one who takes a city.
33 The lot is thrown into the lap,
but every decision from it comes from Yahweh.

Notes

- a (16:1) The Septuagint lacks verses 1, 3, 4, and 6 in this form; forms of verses 6–9 also appear at the end of chapter 15.

Chapter 17

1 A dry crust eaten in quiet
beats a house full of feasting[a] with quarrels.

2 A servant with good sense will rule over a son who brings shame
and share the inheritance with the brothers.
3 The crucible is for silver and the furnace for gold,
but Yahweh is the tester of hearts.
4 An evildoer listens closely to wicked lips;
a liar lends his ear to a ruinous tongue.
5 To mock the poor is to insult the one who made them;
the person glad at disaster will not escape punishment.
6 Grandchildren are the crown of the old,
and parents are the pride of their children.[b]
7 Fine speech does not suit a fool,
still less lying lips a noble.
8 A bribe is a lucky stone in its owner's eyes;
wherever he turns, it brings success.
9 To cover an offense is to seek love;
to keep bringing it up splits close friends.
10 A reprimand sinks further into someone with discernment
than a hundred lashes into a fool.
11 Rebellion is all an evil man is after;
a merciless envoy will be dispatched to deal with him.
12 Meet a bear robbed of her cubs
rather than a fool in his folly.
13 If someone pays back evil for good,
evil will never leave his house.
14 Starting a quarrel is like letting out water;
so drop the matter before the dispute breaks out.
15 Acquitting the guilty and condemning the innocent—
Yahweh detests both alike.
16 What good is money in a fool's hand
to buy wisdom, when he has no mind for it?[c]
17 A friend loves at all times,
and a brother is born for the hard times.
18 A man without sense strikes hands in pledge
and puts up security for his neighbor.

19 The lover of offense is a lover of strife;
whoever builds his gate high is asking for a fall.
20 One crooked of heart finds no good,
and one with a twisted tongue falls into trouble.
21 Whoever fathers a fool gets grief,
and the father of a dolt has no joy.
22 A glad heart is good medicine,
but a broken spirit dries up the bones.
23 A wicked man takes a bribe from under his cloak[d]
to bend the paths of justice.
24 The discerning keeps wisdom in view,
but the eyes of a fool roam to the ends of the earth.
25 A foolish child grieves his father
and brings sorrow to the mother who bore him.
26 To fine the innocent is not good,
nor to flog nobles for their uprightness.
27 Whoever holds back his words has knowledge,
and the cool of spirit is a person of understanding.
28 Even a fool who keeps silent is counted wise;
with closed lips he passes for discerning.

Notes

- a (17:1) Literally "sacrifices," since meat was eaten at sacrificial meals.
- b (17:6) The Septuagint adds "The faithful have a whole world of wealth, but the faithless not even a penny."
- c (17:16) The Septuagint adds "Whoever makes his own house high seeks ruin, and whoever turns aside from learning will fall into trouble."
- d (17:23) Literally "from the bosom," the fold of the garment.

Chapter 18

1 One who separates himself pursues his own desire;
he bursts out against all sound judgment.[a]
2 A fool takes no pleasure in understanding,
only in airing his own opinions.
3 When wickedness arrives, contempt comes too,
and with dishonor comes reproach.

4 The words of a man's mouth are deep waters,
the spring of wisdom a flowing stream.
5 It is not good to favor the guilty
or to push aside the innocent in court.
6 The lips of a fool march him into strife;
his mouth begs for blows.
7 A fool's mouth is his ruin,
and his lips are a snare to his life.
8 The words of a whisperer are like tasty morsels;
they go down into the inner rooms of the belly.
9 Whoever is slack in his work
is brother to the one who destroys.
10 Yahweh's name is a fortified tower;
the righteous run to it and are safe above reach.
11 A rich man's wealth is his strong city,
and in his imagination it is like a high wall.
12 Before ruin a man's heart grows proud,
and humility comes before honor.
13 Whoever answers before he has heard
shows his folly and his shame.
14 A person's spirit can bear his sickness,
but a crushed spirit—who can carry it?
15 The discerning heart acquires knowledge,
and the ear of the wise searches it out.
16 A man's gift opens the way for him
and brings him before the great.
17 The first to state his case seems right,
until the other side comes and questions him.
18 The lot puts an end to disputes
and settles things between the powerful.
19 An offended relative is harder to win over than a walled city,
and disputes are like the bolts of a citadel.[b]
20 From the fruit of a man's mouth his belly is filled;
he is filled with the yield of his lips.

21 Death and life are in the power of the tongue,
and those who love it will eat its fruit.
22 He who finds a wife finds a good thing
and obtains favor from Yahweh.[c]
23 The poor man speaks in pleading tones,
but the rich man answers roughly.[d]
24 A man of many companions may come to ruin,
but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.

Notes

- a (18:1) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- b (18:19) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- c (18:22) The Septuagint adds "Whoever puts away a good wife puts away a good thing, and whoever keeps an adulteress is foolish and ungodly."
- d (18:23) The Septuagint lacks verses 23–24 and 19:1–2.

Chapter 19

1 Better a poor man walking in his integrity
than one with twisted lips who is a fool.
2 Desire without knowledge is not good,
and whoever hurries with his feet misses the way.
3 A man's own folly ruins his way,
and his heart rages against Yahweh.
4 Wealth adds many friends,
but the poor man is deserted by his friend.
5 The liar on the witness stand will be held guilty;
whoever puffs out falsehoods will not get away.
6 Many seek the goodwill of a generous person,
and everyone befriends the one who hands out presents.
7 All the brothers of a poor man hate him;
how much more do his friends keep away from him!
He chases after them with words, but they are gone.[a]
8 Whoever gets sense loves his own life;
whoever keeps understanding will find good.
9 The liar on the witness stand will be held guilty;
whoever puffs out falsehoods will perish.

10 Luxury does not suit a fool,
still less a slave ruling over princes.
11 A person's good sense makes him slow to anger,
and it is his glory to overlook an offense.
12 A king's fury is like a lion's roar,
but his goodwill is like dew falling on the lawn.
13 A stupid son brings disaster on his father,
and a nagging wife is a roof that leaks without stopping.
14 A house and riches come down from one's ancestors;
a wife with insight is Yahweh's gift.
15 Laziness casts into a deep sleep,
and an idle person will go hungry.
16 Whoever keeps the commandment keeps his life;
whoever is careless of his ways will die.
17 Whoever is kind to the poor lends to Yahweh,
and he will repay him for his deed.
18 Train your son while hope remains;
do not lift your soul toward putting him to death.[b]
19 A man of great wrath will pay the penalty;
if you rescue him, you will have to do it again.
20 Hear counsel, take correction,
and in the end you will be wise.
21 Many are the plans in a man's heart,
but it is Yahweh's purpose that will stand.
22 What is desired in a person is loyal love,[c]
and a poor man is better than a liar.
23 The fear of Yahweh leads to life;
one has it and rests content, untouched by harm.
24 The lazy man plunges his hand into the bowl
and is too tired to lift it back to his lips.
25 Strike a mocker, and the naive will learn shrewdness;
correct a discerning person, and he will gain knowledge.
26 Whoever robs his father and drives out his mother
is a son who brings shame and disgrace.

27 Stop listening to discipline, my son,
and you will stray from words of knowledge.
28 A worthless witness mocks at justice,
and the mouth of the wicked swallows iniquity.
29 Judgments are ready for mockers,
and beatings for the backs of fools.

Notes

- a (19:7) The third line is uncertain; it may be a fragment of a lost saying. The Septuagint has a longer text here.
- b (19:18) Or "do not set your heart on causing him to die," that is, do not discipline in rage; or "do not let your heart be set on ruining him" by neglect.
- c (19:22) Or "A person's greed is his shame."

Chapter 20

1 Wine is a scoffer, strong drink a brawler;
no one led astray by it is wise.
2 A king's fury is like the growl of a young lion;
whoever angers him forfeits his life.
3 It is to a man's credit to keep clear of strife,
but every fool bares his teeth.
4 The lazy man does not plow when autumn comes;
at harvest he looks for a crop and there is none.
5 The purpose in a person's heart is deep water,
but a discerning person will draw it up.
6 Plenty of people advertise their own devotion,
but who can locate someone truly trustworthy?
7 The righteous walks on in his integrity;
happy are his children after him!
8 A king seated on the throne of judgment
sifts out all evil with his eyes.
9 Who can say, "I have made my heart clean;
I am pure from my sin"?[a]
10 Two kinds of weights and two kinds of measures[b]—
Yahweh detests both of them.

11 Even a child makes himself known by his acts,
whether his conduct is pure and upright.
12 A listening ear, a seeing eye—
Yahweh is the maker of the pair.
13 Do not love sleep, or you will be poor;
keep your eyes open and you will have your fill of bread.
14 "Bad, bad," says the buyer,
but when he goes off, then he boasts.[c]
15 There is gold and plenty of coral,
but lips with knowledge are the rarest jewel.
16 Take the garment of one who stands surety for a stranger;
hold it as a pledge when he guarantees a foreign woman.[d]
17 Food got by cheating tastes sweet at first,
but later the mouth is crammed with grit.
18 Plans are made firm by taking counsel;
wage war with sound guidance.
19 A gossip goes around revealing secrets,
so do not mix with someone whose lips are always open.
20 Whoever curses his father or his mother,
his lamp will go out in deepest darkness.
21 An inheritance seized in haste at the start
will not be blessed in the end.
22 Do not say, "I will pay back evil";
wait for Yahweh, and he will rescue you.
23 Two kinds of weights are detestable to Yahweh,
and false scales are not good.
24 A man's steps are from Yahweh;
how then can a person understand his own way?
25 It is a snare to blurt out, "Holy!"
and only afterward to think over one's vows.
26 A wise king winnows the wicked
and drives the threshing wheel over them.
27 The human spirit is the lamp of Yahweh,
searching all the inner rooms of the belly.

28 Loyal love and faithfulness guard a king,
and by loyal love he holds up his throne.
29 The glory of young men is their strength,
and the splendor of the old is gray hair.
30 Blows that wound scour away evil,
and beatings reach the inner rooms of the belly.

Notes

- a (20:9) In the Septuagint verses 20–22 follow here, and verses 14–19 are absent.
- b (20:10) Literally "a stone and a stone, an ephah and an ephah," that is, one set of weights and measures for buying and another for selling. The ephah was a dry measure of about 3/5 bushel (22 liters).
- c (20:14) The Septuagint lacks verses 14–19.
- d (20:16) Or "a foreigner," following another reading of the Hebrew; compare 27:13.

Chapter 21

1 A king's heart is a stream of water in Yahweh's hand;
he turns it wherever he pleases.
2 Every way a man takes is right in his own eyes,
but Yahweh weighs hearts.
3 Doing righteousness and justice
pleases Yahweh better than sacrifice.
4 Haughty eyes and a proud heart—
the lamp of the wicked is sin.[a]
5 The plans of the diligent lead only to profit,
but everyone who is hasty comes only to want.[b]
6 Treasures gained by a lying tongue
are a vanishing vapor, snares of death.[c]
7 The violence of the wicked will sweep them away,
because they refuse to do what is just.
8 The way of a guilty man is crooked,
but the conduct of the pure is upright.
9 Better a spot on a corner of the rooftop
than a whole house with a contentious woman.
10 The soul of the wicked craves evil;
his neighbor finds no mercy in his eyes.

11 When a mocker is punished, the naive becomes wise;
when the wise is instructed, he gains knowledge.
12 The Righteous One[d] takes note of the wicked man's house
and hurls the wicked into disaster.
13 Whoever closes his ears to a poor person's plea
will call out himself and receive no reply.
14 A gift in secret soothes anger,
and a bribe in the cloak, strong wrath.
15 Justice carried out delights the righteous
and terrifies those who do wrong.
16 A person who strays off the road of insight
will end up resting among the company of the shades.
17 Whoever loves pleasure will be a poor man;
whoever loves wine and oil will not grow rich.
18 The wicked is a ransom for the righteous,
and the treacherous for the upright.
19 Better to live in a desert land
than with a quarrelsome and fretful wife.
20 Precious treasure and oil are in the dwelling of the wise,
but a foolish man swallows them up.
21 Whoever pursues righteousness and loyal love
finds life, righteousness, and honor.
22 A wise man goes up against a city of warriors
and brings down the stronghold they trusted.
23 Keep watch on mouth and tongue,
and you keep your soul out of distress.
24 "Mocker" is the name of the proud and arrogant man
who acts with insolent pride.
25 The craving of the sluggard kills him,
for his hands refuse to work.
26 He spends the whole day longing for more;
the righteous man gives without stinting.
27 The sacrifice of the wicked is detestable,
how much more when he brings it with evil intent!

28 A lying witness will perish,
but a man who listens will speak to the end.[e]
29 The wicked man hardens his face;
the upright man makes his ways sure.[f]
30 There is no wisdom, no understanding,
no counsel against Yahweh.
31 They harness the horse for the day of war,
yet the victory is Yahweh's.

Notes

- a (21:4) Or "the tillage of the wicked"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- b (21:5) The Septuagint lacks this verse.
- c (21:6) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Hebrew reads "for those who seek death."
- d (21:12) Or "A righteous man"; the subject of the second line suggests God.
- e (21:28) Or "will speak successfully"; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (21:29) So the Masoretic marginal reading; the written text has "understands his ways."

Chapter 22

1 A good name is to be chosen over great riches;
favor is better than silver and gold.
2 Rich and poor meet together;
Yahweh is the Maker of them all.
3 The shrewd sees trouble and hides,
but the naive go on and pay for it.
4 The reward of humility and the fear of Yahweh
is riches and honor and life.
5 Thorns and snares lie in the way of the crooked;
whoever guards his life keeps far from them.
6 Train a child in keeping with his way;
even when he is old he will not turn from it.[a]
7 The rich rules over the poor,
and the borrower is slave to the lender.
8 Whoever sows injustice will reap trouble,
and the rod of his fury will fail.[b]

9 The generous will be blessed,
for he shares his bread with the poor.[c]
10 Drive out the mocker and strife goes out;
quarreling and insult will stop.
11 One who loves a pure heart and has grace on his lips
will win the king's friendship.
12 The eyes of Yahweh watch over knowledge,
but he overturns the words of the treacherous.
13 The sluggard says, "There is a lion outside!
I will be killed in the streets!"
14 The mouth of foreign women is a deep pit;
the one under Yahweh's anger will fall into it.[d]
15 Folly is bound up in the heart of a boy;
the rod of discipline will drive it far from him.
16 Grinding down the poor to enrich oneself,
giving presents to the rich—both end in want.
17 Incline your ear and listen to the sayings of the wise,[e]
and apply your mind to what I know,
18 for it is pleasant if you keep them within you,
if all of them are ready on your lips.
19 so that you may rely on Yahweh,
I am teaching you these things today, you in particular.
20 See, I have written down for you thirty[f]
of counsel and knowledge,
21 to teach you what is right and true, words that can be relied on,
so that you can bring back a true answer to those who sent you?
22 Do not plunder a poor man just because he is poor,
and do not trample the lowly in the gate,
23 for Yahweh will plead their case
and rob of life those who rob them.
24 Do not befriend a hot-tempered man,
or go around with a man of rage,
25 or you will learn his ways
and get yourself caught in a snare.

26 Do not be one of those who strike hands in pledge,
who stand as security for debts.
27 If you have nothing to pay with,
why should your bed be taken from under you?
28 Do not move the ancient boundary stone
that your fathers set up.
29 You see a man who is quick and expert at his trade?
Before kings he will take his place,
not before men of no account.

Notes

- a (22:6) Or "according to the way he should go." The Septuagint lacks this verse.
- b (22:8) The Septuagint adds "God loves a cheerful and generous man, but he will bring the emptiness of his works to an end"; compare 2 Corinthians 9:7.
- c (22:9) The Septuagint adds "Whoever gives freely wins victory and honor, but he takes away the life of those who possess them."
- d (22:14) The Septuagint adds "Evil ways lie before a man, and he does not like to turn from them, but he must turn aside from a twisted and evil way."
- e (22:17) A new collection begins here (22:17–24:22), with close parallels in the Egyptian Instruction of Amenemope, which is divided into thirty chapters.
- f (22:20) So the Masoretic marginal reading, as many interpreters understand it; the written text reads shilshom, "formerly," and the marginal reading shalishim is also taken as "excellent things." The Septuagint reads "record them for yourself three times."

Chapter 23

1 When you take your seat to eat with someone in power,
pay close attention to what[a] is in front of you,
2 and put a knife to your throat
if you have a large appetite.
3 Have no longing for his dainties,
since that bread is a lie.
4 Do not wear yourself out getting rich;
have the sense to stop.
5 Let your eyes light on it, and it is gone,
for it will surely sprout wings
and fly off into the sky like an eagle.

6 Do not eat the bread of a stingy man[b]
or crave his delicacies,
7 for he is like someone keeping accounts in his head.[c]
"Eat and drink!" he tells you,
but his heart is not with you.
8 You will bring up the little you have eaten
and ruin your pleasant conversation.
9 Waste no words on a fool's ears;
he will look down on your sensible speech.
10 Do not move the ancient boundary stone
or go into the fields of the fatherless,
11 for their Redeemer[d] is strong;
he will plead their case against you.
12 Apply your mind to instruction,
your ear to the sayings of knowledge.
13 Do not hold back discipline from a boy;
if you strike him with the rod, he will not die.
14 Strike him with the rod yourself,
and you will rescue his life from Sheol.
15 My son, if your heart is wise,
my own heart too will be glad;
16 my very kidneys[e] will cheer
at the upright things your lips say.
17 Do not let your heart be jealous of sinners,
but stay in the fear of Yahweh all day.
18 There is surely a future,
and your hope will not be cut off.
19 Hear, my son; grow wise;
steer your heart down the road.
20 Do not be among those who guzzle wine
or those who gorge themselves on meat,
21 for the drunkard and the glutton will come to poverty,
and drowsiness will dress them in rags.

22 Listen to your father, who gave you life,
and do not despise your mother when she is old.
23 Buy truth and do not sell it—
wisdom, discipline, and understanding.
24 The father of a righteous son will shout for joy;
whoever fathers a wise son will be glad in him.
25 Let your father and your mother be glad;
let her who bore you rejoice.
26 My son, give me your heart,
and let your eyes take pleasure in[f] my ways.
27 For a prostitute is a deep pit,
and a foreign woman a narrow well.
28 She lies in wait like a robber
and adds to the number of the treacherous among men.
29 Who has woe? Who has sorrow?
Who has quarrels? Who has complaints?
Who has wounds for no reason?
Who has bloodshot eyes?
30 Those who linger late over wine,
who go in search of mixed wine.
31 Do not stare at wine when it is red,
when it sparkles in the cup
and goes down smoothly.
32 In the end it bites like a snake
and stings like a viper.
33 Your eyes will see strange sights,
and your heart will speak twisted things.
34 You will be like someone lying down in the middle of the sea,
like someone lying on top of a mast.[g]
35 "I was hit," you say, "and it did not hurt me;
I was thrashed, and I never noticed.
How long till I am awake?
I will go after it again."

Notes

- a (23:1) Or “who.”
- b (23:6) Literally “of one evil of eye.”
- c (23:7) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain; or “as he calculates in his soul, so is he.”
- d (23:11) Hebrew go’el, the next of kin who defends a family member’s rights; here God himself.
- e (23:16) Hebrew “kidneys,” thought of as the seat of the deepest feelings.
- f (23:26) So the written Hebrew text; the Masoretic marginal reading has “keep.”
- g (23:34) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.

Chapter 24

1 Do not envy evil men
or long to be in their company,
2 for their hearts plot violence
and their lips talk of trouble.
3 By wisdom a house is built,
and by understanding it is made firm;
4 by knowledge its rooms are filled
with all kinds of precious and pleasant riches.
5 A wise man is strong,[a]
and a man of knowledge adds to his power,
6 for with guidance you will wage your war,
and with many counselors there is victory.
7 Wisdom is out of a fool’s reach;
at the city gate he has nothing to say.
8 Whoever plans to do evil
will be called a master schemer.
9 The scheming of folly is sin,
and the mocker is detestable to people.
10 If you lose heart in the day of trouble,
your strength is small.
11 Rescue those being taken away to death;
hold back those stumbling toward the slaughter.
12 If you say, “See, we did not know this,”
does not the one who weighs hearts perceive it?

Does not the one who guards your life know it?
Will he not repay a person according to his work?
13 Eat honey, my son, for it is good,
and the honeycomb is sweet to your taste.
14 Understand that wisdom is the same for your soul;
if you obtain it, you will have a future,
and your hope will never be severed.
15 Do not lie in wait, wicked man, against the dwelling of the righteous;
do not destroy his resting place,
16 for seven times the righteous man may fall and get up again,
but the wicked are tripped up by disaster.
17 When your enemy goes down, do not celebrate;
when he trips, keep your heart from gloating,
18 lest Yahweh look on with disapproval
and withdraw his anger from that man.
19 Do not fret because of evildoers
or envy the wicked,
20 for there is no tomorrow for the evildoer;
the light of the wicked will go out.
21 My son, fear Yahweh and the king;
do not mix with those who change sides,[b]
22 for disaster from them will rise suddenly,
and who knows the ruin both of them can bring?[c]
23 These also are sayings of the wise:[d]
To show partiality in judgment is not good.
24 Anyone who tells a guilty man, "You are in the right,"
will be cursed by peoples and damned by nations,
25 but those who convict the guilty will find delight,
and a rich blessing will come upon them.
26 He kisses the lips
who gives an honest answer.

27 Set your outdoor tasks in order;
get your fields ready,
and only then build your house.
28 Do not testify against your neighbor for no reason;
would you mislead with your lips?
29 Do not say, "I will treat him the way he treated me;
I will repay him for his deed."
30 I went past a lazy man's field,
past the vineyard of a senseless man,
31 and behold, thistles had overrun all of it;
nettles blanketed the ground,
and its stone fence had collapsed.
32 I looked and took it to heart;
I saw and received instruction:
33 a little sleep, a little slumber,
a little folding of the hands to rest,
34 and poverty will come on you like a prowler,
and want like an armed man.[e]

Notes

- a (24:5) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Hebrew reads "A wise man is in strength."
- b (24:21) Or "with those of high rank"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (24:22) The Septuagint adds a long passage here (verses 22a–e in some editions) on the son who keeps the commandment and on the king's tongue as a sword. In the Septuagint, 30:1–14 also follows here.
- d (24:23) A short collection begins here (24:23–34).
- e (24:34) In the Septuagint, 30:15–33 and 31:1–9 follow this verse; chapters 25–29 come next, and then 31:10–31.

Chapter 25

1 These too are proverbs of Solomon, which the men of Hezekiah[a] king of Judah copied out.
2 It is God's glory to keep a thing hidden
and the glory of kings to search a matter through.
3 As the heavens for height and the earth for depth,
so the heart of kings is past searching out.

4 Clear the dross away from the silver,
and a vessel comes out for the smith;
5 clear the wicked away from the king's presence,
and his throne will be made firm by righteousness.
6 Do not put yourself forward in the king's presence
or take your stand in the place of the great,
7 since being invited, "Move up higher," beats
being demoted before a noble
whom you have laid eyes on.[b]
8 Do not rush out to bring a quarrel to court,
for what will you do at the end
when your neighbor puts you to shame?
9 Argue your case with your neighbor himself,
and do not give away another's secret,
10 or whoever hears will reproach you,
and your bad name will never go away.[c]
11 Apples of gold in settings of silver—
so is a word spoken at the right time.[d]
12 A gold ring, an ornament of fine gold—
so is a wise man's rebuke to a listening ear.
13 Like the cool of snow on a harvest day
is a faithful messenger to those who send him;
he refreshes his master's spirit.
14 Clouds and wind but no rain—
so is a man who boasts of a gift he never gives.
15 With patience a ruler may be won over,
and a soft tongue can break a bone.
16 Found honey? Eat just what you need,
or you will have too much and vomit it up.
17 Let your foot be seldom in your neighbor's house,
or he will have his fill of you and hate you.
18 A war club, a sword, a sharpened arrow—
so is a man who testifies falsely against his neighbor.

19 A bad tooth, a slipping foot—
so is trust in a traitor on a day of trouble.
20 Like taking off a cloak on a cold day, like vinegar poured on soda,[e]
so is one who sings songs to a heavy heart.[f]
21 If the one who hates you is hungry, give him bread to eat;
if he is thirsty, give him water to drink,
22 So you will be piling live coals on his head,[g]
and Yahweh will reward you.
23 The north wind brings forth rain,
and a secretive tongue, angry looks.[h]
24 Better a spot on a corner of the rooftop
than a whole house with a contentious woman.
25 Cold water for a parched throat—
such is good news from a distant land.
26 Like a muddied spring or a polluted well
is a righteous man who gives way before the wicked.
27 To eat much honey is not good,
nor to search out one's own glory.[i]
28 Like a city breached, left without walls,
is a man who has no control of his spirit.

Notes

- a (25:1) Hezekiah means "Yahweh strengthens." He was king of Judah about 715–686 BC (2 Kings 18–20).
- b (25:7) The last line may belong with verse 8.
- c (25:10) The Septuagint adds "Favor and friendship set a person free; keep them for yourself, so that you do not become a target of reproach, but guard your ways peaceably."
- d (25:11) The meaning of the Hebrew for "settings" is uncertain; or "carvings."
- e (25:20) Hebrew nether, natron, a natural soda that fizzes when vinegar is poured on it.
- f (25:20) The Septuagint adds "Like a moth in a garment and a worm in wood, so a man's grief harms the heart."
- g (25:22) An image of making him burn with shame, or perhaps drawn from an Egyptian rite of penitence; quoted in Romans 12:20.
- h (25:23) In Israel rain comes mostly from the west; "north" may mean "northwest," or the saying may come from elsewhere.
- i (25:27) The second line is uncertain; or "but to search out difficult things is glory."

Chapter 26

1 Like snow in summer or rain at harvest,
honor does not fit a fool.
2 Like a flitting sparrow, like a darting swallow,
a curse without cause does not land.[a]
3 A whip for the horse, a bridle for the donkey,
and a rod for the backs of fools.
4 Do not answer a fool by his own folly,
or you will become like him yourself.
5 Answer a fool by his own folly,
or he will think himself wise.[b]
6 Whoever sends a message by a fool
cuts off his own feet and drinks down violence.
7 Like legs dangling uselessly from a lame man
is a proverb in the mouth of fools.
8 Like tying a stone into a sling
is giving honor to a fool.
9 A thorn that springs up in a drunkard's grip—
such is a proverb in the mouths of fools.
10 An archer piercing all comers—
such is the man who hires a fool, or hires whoever happens along.[c]
11 Like a dog that goes back to its vomit
is a fool who repeats his folly.[d]
12 Do you see a man wise in his own eyes?
There is more hope for a fool than for him.
13 The sluggard says, "There is a lion in the road!
A lion loose in the squares!"
14 The door turns on its hinge,
and the sluggard on his bed.
15 The sluggard buries his hand in the dish;
he is too weary to bring it back to his mouth.
16 The sluggard is wiser in his own eyes
than seven people who answer sensibly.

17 Whoever seizes a passing dog by its ears
is like one who meddles in someone else's quarrel.
18 Like a madman shooting
firebrands, arrows, and death
19 is the man who deceives his neighbor
and says, "I was only joking!"
20 Where there is no wood, the fire goes out;
where there is no whisperer, quarreling dies down.
21 Charcoal to embers and wood to fire—
so is a quarrelsome man for kindling strife.
22 The words of a whisperer are like tasty morsels;
they go down into the inner rooms of the belly.
23 Like a glaze of silver dross over clay
are burning lips with an evil heart.[e]
24 A man full of hate puts on a mask with his talk,
but inside he lays up treachery.
25 When he speaks graciously, do not believe him,
for seven abominations are in his heart.
26 Though his hatred is covered with guile,
his evil will be exposed in the assembly.
27 Dig a pit and you will drop into it;
roll a stone and it will come rolling back on you.
28 A tongue that lies hates its victims;
a smooth mouth brings about a downfall.

Notes

- a (26:2) So the Masoretic marginal reading; the written text has "does not come to it," perhaps "does not come to him," the one who utters it.
- b (26:5) Verses 4 and 5 are set side by side on purpose: whether to answer a fool depends on the case.
- c (26:10) The Hebrew of this verse is very obscure. Other proposals include "A master craftsman makes everything, but one who hires a fool is like one who hires passers-by."
- d (26:11) Quoted in 2 Peter 2:22. The Septuagint adds "There is a shame that brings sin, and there is a shame that is glory and grace."
- e (26:23) Or, with a slight change of the Hebrew, "like glaze over clay"; a Ugaritic word suggests "silver dross" should be read as "glaze."

Chapter 27

1 Do not brag about tomorrow;
you have no idea what today will give birth to.
2 Let another praise you, not your own mouth;
a stranger, and not your own lips.
3 A stone is heavy and sand a burden,
but a fool's provocation weighs more than both.
4 Fury is savage, anger an overflowing flood,
but jealousy—who can hold out against it?
5 Better an open rebuke
than love kept hidden.
6 Faithful are the wounds of a friend,
but the kisses of an enemy are profuse.[a]
7 A full stomach tramples on honey,
but to a hungry stomach everything bitter is sweet.
8 A bird wandering far from its nest,
a man wandering far from his place—they are alike.
9 Oil and incense gladden the heart,
and the sweetness of a friend comes from heartfelt counsel.[b]
10 Do not abandon your own friend or your father's;
on your day of trouble, do not head for your brother's house;
a neighbor close at hand beats a brother who is far.
11 Be wise, my son, and gladden my heart,
so that I can answer anyone who taunts me.
12 The shrewd sees trouble and hides;
the naive go on and pay for it.
13 Take the garment of one who stands surety for a stranger;
hold it as a pledge when he guarantees a foreign woman.
14 Whoever blesses his neighbor with a loud voice early in the morning,
it will be counted to him as a curse.
15 A steady dripping on a rainy day
and a quarrelsome wife are alike;

16 whoever would hold her back holds back the wind,
and his right hand meets only oil.[c]
17 Iron sharpens iron,
and one person sharpens the face of another.[d]
18 The keeper of a fig tree eats its figs;
the one who guards his master gets respect.
19 As water reflects face to face,
so the heart of a person reflects the person.
20 Sheol and Abaddon can never get enough,
nor can the eyes of humankind.[e]
21 The crucible is for silver and the furnace for gold,
and a person is tested by the praise he receives.[f]
22 Though you pound a fool in a mortar,
in among the grain with a pestle,
his folly will not depart from him.
23 Know well the condition of your flocks;
set your heart on your herds,
24 for wealth does not last for all time,
and a crown is not passed down age after age.
25 When the hay is gone and the new growth appears
and the grass of the hills is gathered in,
26 lambs will supply your garments,
and goats will pay for a field,
27 and you will have goats' milk in plenty to eat,
to feed your whole household,
and to keep your servant girls alive.

Notes

- a (27:6) Or "deceitful," from a different understanding of the Hebrew.
- b (27:9) The second line is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "but the soul is torn by calamities."
- c (27:16) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- d (27:17) Or "so one person sharpens another."
- e (27:20) The Septuagint adds "Whoever fixes his eye is detestable to the Lord, and the uninstructed do not restrain their tongue."
- f (27:21) The Septuagint adds "The heart of the lawless seeks out mischief, but an upright heart seeks knowledge."

Chapter 28

1 The wicked run off with no one chasing them,
but the righteous are as bold as a young lion.
2 When a land rebels, its rulers are many,
but with a man of understanding and knowledge, order lasts.[a]
3 A poor man who grinds down the poor
is a driving rain that leaves no bread.
4 Those who abandon instruction[b] praise the wicked;
those who keep instruction fight against them.
5 Evil men have no grasp of justice;
those who seek Yahweh grasp it fully.
6 A poor man walking in his integrity is better off
than a rich man crooked in his two ways.
7 A son with understanding keeps the instruction,
but one who keeps company with gluttons shames his father.
8 One who swells his wealth by interest and profiteering
gathers it for someone who will be kind to the poor.
9 If one turns his ear from hearing instruction,
even his prayer is detestable.
10 Whoever leads the upright astray onto an evil road
will drop into his own pit,
but the blameless will inherit good.
11 A rich man is wise in his own sight,
but a poor man with discernment sees right through him.
12 When the righteous triumph, there is great splendor,
but when the wicked rise, people go into hiding.
13 Whoever covers up his wrongs will not prosper,
but whoever confesses and leaves them will find mercy.
14 Happy is the one who is always in awe,
but whoever hardens his heart tumbles into trouble.
15 A roaring lion, a charging bear—
such is a wicked ruler over a helpless people.
16 A prince who lacks understanding is a great oppressor,
but one who hates unjust gain will prolong his days.

17 A man burdened with another's lifeblood
will flee to the pit; let no one hold him back.[c]
18 One who walks blamelessly will be kept safe,
but one crooked in his two ways will fall all at once.[d]
19 Whoever works his land will be filled with bread;
whoever chases empty things will be filled with poverty.
20 A trustworthy man has blessings in abundance;
a man racing to wealth will not stay innocent.
21 Favoritism is not good,
yet a man will do wrong for a piece of bread.
22 The stingy man[e] hurries after wealth
and does not know that want will come to him.
23 Whoever rebukes a man will in the end find more favor
than one who flatters with his tongue.
24 Whoever robs his father or mother and says, "It is no crime,"
is partner to a destroyer.
25 The greedy stirs up strife,
but whoever trusts in Yahweh will grow fat.
26 Whoever trusts in his own heart is a fool,
but whoever walks in wisdom will escape.
27 One who gives to the poor will never lack,
but one who shuts his eyes will get many curses.
28 When the wicked rise, people hide;
when they perish, the righteous multiply.

Notes

- a (28:2) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- b (28:4) Hebrew torah, here probably the teaching of the wise as well as the law of God; so also in verses 7 and 9.
- c (28:17) The Septuagint adds "Discipline your son, and he will love you and bring honor to your soul; he will not obey a lawless nation."
- d (28:18) Or "will fall into a pit," reading one letter differently.
- e (28:22) Literally "the man evil of eye," as in 23:6.

Chapter 29

1 Someone corrected again and again who keeps a stiff neck
will be shattered in a moment, past all mending.

2 When the righteous increase, the people rejoice,
but when a wicked man rules, the people groan.
3 A man who loves wisdom gladdens his father,
but one who keeps company with prostitutes squanders his wealth.
4 By justice a king gives a land stability,
but a man of levies[a] tears it down.
5 A man who flatters his neighbor
spreads a net for his feet.
6 In the offense of an evil man there is a snare,
but the righteous sings and rejoices.
7 The righteous knows the rights of the poor;
the wicked has no such understanding.
8 Mockers set a city ablaze,
but the wise turn anger away.
9 When a wise man goes to law with a fool,
the fool rages and laughs, and there is no rest.
10 Men of blood hate the blameless,
and as for the upright, they seek his life.[b]
11 A fool lets out all his temper,
but a wise man holds it back and calms it.
12 When a ruler pays heed to lies,
every one of his servants turns wicked.
13 The poor man and the oppressor meet together;
Yahweh gives light to the eyes of both.
14 A king who judges the poor faithfully
will have his throne made firm forever.
15 The rod and rebuke give wisdom,
but a boy left to himself shames his mother.
16 As the wicked multiply, so does transgression,
and the righteous will look on at their fall.
17 Discipline your son, and he will give you rest;
he will bring delight to your soul.

18 Where there is no vision,[c] the people run wild,
but happy is the one who keeps the instruction.
19 A servant cannot be corrected by words alone;
he understands, but he does not respond.
20 Do you see a man hasty with his words?
There is more hope for a fool than for him.
21 Whoever pampers his servant from youth
will find him a weakling[d] in the end.
22 An angry man stirs up strife,
and a hot-tempered man is full of offenses.
23 A man's pride will bring him low,
but the lowly in spirit will take hold of honor.
24 To go shares with a thief is to hate yourself;
you hear the oath and say nothing.[e]
25 Fear of people sets a snare,
but whoever trusts in Yahweh is set high and safe.
26 Many seek a ruler's face,
but a man's justice comes from Yahweh.
27 The righteous loathe the man of injustice;
the wicked loathe the man of the straight road.

Notes

- a (29:4) Hebrew terumot, contributions, perhaps forced gifts or heavy taxes.
- b (29:10) Or "but the upright care for his life."
- c (29:18) Hebrew hazon, prophetic revelation.
- d (29:21) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; or "an heir," or "a cause of grief."
- e (29:24) A public curse was pronounced on any witness who withheld testimony (Leviticus 5:1).

Chapter 30

1 The words of Agur[a] son of Jakeh, the oracle.[b]
This man's utterance to Ithiel, to Ithiel and Ucal:[c]
2 I am more brute than man;
I lack a human's understanding.
3 I have not learned wisdom,
nor do I have knowledge of the Holy One.

4 Who has gone up to the heavens and come down?
Who has gathered the wind in the hollow of his hands?
Who has wrapped up the waters in a cloak?
Who has fixed all the ends of the earth?
What is his name, and what is his son's name?
Surely you know!
5 Every word of God has been through the fire;
he is a shield to those who take refuge in him.
6 Do not tack anything onto what he says,
lest he call you to account and you stand exposed as false.
7 Two things I request from you;
do not hold them back from me as long as I live:
8 Keep falsehood and lying words far from me;
give me neither poverty nor riches;
feed me with my portion of bread,
9 or I may have too much and deny you
and say, "Who is Yahweh?"
or I may be poor and steal
and do violence to the name of my God.
10 Never run down a slave to his owner,
lest he call down a curse on you and you be held guilty.
11 There is a breed of people who curse their fathers
and give no blessing to their mothers,
12 a generation pure in its own eyes
yet not washed of its filth,
13 a generation—how lofty its eyes,
how raised its eyelids!—
14 a generation whose teeth are swords,
whose jaws are knives,
to devour the poor from the earth
and the needy from among humankind.
15 The leech[d] has a pair of daughters,
"Give!" and "Give!"
Three there are that are never full,
four that never cry, "Plenty!":

16 Sheol, the barren womb,
earth that never has its fill of water,
and fire that never says, “Enough!”
17 An eye that sneers at a father
and makes light of a mother’s word
will be picked out by the valley ravens
and eaten by the young vultures.
18 Three things are beyond me,
four I cannot fathom:
19 how a vulture finds its way through the air,
how a snake finds its way over rock,
how a ship finds its way in the heart of the sea,
and how a man finds his way with a young woman.[e]
20 This is the way of an adulterous woman:
she eats and wipes her mouth
and says, “I have done nothing wrong.”
21 Three things make the earth shudder,
four it cannot endure:
22 under a slave when he becomes king,
and a godless fool when he is filled with food,
23 a despised woman who finally marries,
and a maidservant who replaces her mistress.
24 Four things on earth are small,
but they are exceedingly wise:
25 the ants are a people without strength,
yet they store up their food in summer;
26 the hyraxes,[f] a folk with no might,
who set up house among the cliffs;
27 the locusts have no king,
yet all of them march out in ranks;
28 the gecko[g] you can catch in your hand,
yet it is found in kings’ palaces.
29 Three there are with a splendid gait,
four that move with a splendid step:

30 the lion, mightiest among beasts,
who turns back from nothing;
31 the strutting rooster[h] or the he-goat,
and a king with his army around him.[i]
32 If you have been a fool, exalting yourself,
or if you have been plotting evil,
put your hand over your mouth.
33 For pressing milk brings out curds,
pressing the nose brings out blood,
and pressing anger brings out strife.[j]

Notes

- a (30:1) Agur may mean "gatherer" or "hired"; Jakeh perhaps "pious" or "obedient." Nothing more is known of either. The Septuagint does not read these as names; it reads "My son, revere my words, receive them, and repent. These things the man says to those who trust in God, and I cease." In the Septuagint, 30:1–14 stands after 24:22.
- b (30:1) Hebrew hamassa', "the oracle"; or "of Massa," a north Arabian people descended from Ishmael (Genesis 25:14); compare 31:1.
- c (30:1) Ithiel means "God is with me," and Ucal perhaps "I am able." With a different division of the Hebrew consonants the line reads "I am weary, O God; I am weary, O God, and exhausted."
- d (30:15) Hebrew ʿaluqah, perhaps a bloodsucking leech or a mythical vampire-like creature.
- e (30:19) Or "a girl"; Hebrew ʿalmah, a young woman of marriageable age.
- f (30:26) Hebrew shephanim, the rock hyrax, a small animal that lives among rocks.
- g (30:28) Or "lizard" or "spider"; the meaning of the Hebrew semamit is uncertain.
- h (30:31) Hebrew zarzir motnayim, literally "girded of loins"; the animal is uncertain. The Septuagint has "a rooster strutting boldly among the hens"; others suggest a greyhound or a war horse.
- i (30:31) The meaning of the Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- j (30:33) The verse plays on Hebrew 'aph, which means both "nose" and "anger."

Chapter 31

1 The words of Lemuel,[a] king, an oracle[b] that his mother taught him:
2 What, my son? What, son of my womb?
What, son of my vows?
3 Do not hand over your vigor to women
or your ways to the destroyers of kings.

4 Kings, Lemuel, should not drink wine—
kings should not,
and rulers should not long for liquor,
5 lest they drink and lose sight of what is laid down
and pervert the cause of every oppressed person.
6 Let strong drink go to the man who is dying,
wine to those whose souls are bitter;
7 let them drink it down, forget how poor they are,
and think no more of their trouble.
8 Open your mouth for the one who cannot speak,
for the rights of all who are passing away.[c]
9 Open your mouth, judge rightly,
and defend the rights of the poor and needy.
10 A woman of valor[d]—who can find her?
Her worth is far beyond corals.
11 Her husband's heart trusts in her,
and he will never lack for gain.
12 She does him good and not harm
all the days of her life.
13 She looks out for wool and flax
and works them with eager hands.
14 She is like the merchant ships;
she brings her food from far away.
15 While it is yet dark she is up,
setting out food for her house
and a share for her young women.
16 She looks a field over and acquires it;
with what her hands have earned she puts in a vineyard.
17 She wraps her waist in strength
and makes her arms strong.
18 She can taste that her dealings turn a profit;
all night her lamp stays lit.
19 She puts her hands to the distaff,
and her palms grasp the spindle.

20 Her palm is spread out to the poor;
her hands stretch toward the needy.
21 She has no fear of snow for her household,
for all her household are clothed in scarlet.[e]
22 She weaves bed coverings for herself;
she is dressed in fine linen and purple.
23 Her husband is known in the gates
when he takes his seat among the elders of the land.
24 She makes linen garments and sells them
and supplies sashes to the merchant.
25 She is clothed in strength and dignity,
and she smiles at the future.
26 She opens her mouth with wisdom,
and the teaching of loyal love[f] is on her tongue.
27 She keeps watch over the doings of her household
and does not eat the bread of idleness.
28 Her sons stand up and bless her;
her husband joins in her praise:
29 "Many daughters have done valiantly,
but you surpass them all."
30 Charm is deceptive and beauty is a breath,[g]
but a woman who fears Yahweh—she shall be praised.
31 Give her the fruit of her hands,
and let her works praise her in the gates.

Notes

- a (31:1) Lemuel means "belonging to God." He is otherwise unknown; the Septuagint does not read a name here (see the next note).
- b (31:1) Hebrew massa'; or "king of Massa," the north Arabian people mentioned at 30:1. The Septuagint reads "My words have been spoken by God, the oracular answer of a king, whom his mother instructed," and places 31:1–9 after 30:33 within chapter 24.
- c (31:8) Or "who are left desolate"; literally "children of passing away."
- d (31:10) Hebrew 'eshet chayil, a woman of strength, ability, and worth, the phrase used of Ruth (Ruth 3:11) and at 12:4. Verses 10–31 are an alphabetic acrostic: each verse begins with the next of the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet, from aleph in verse 10 through bet (11), gimel (12), dalet (13), he (14), vav (15), zayin

(16), het (17), tet (18), yod (19), kaf (20), lamed (21), mem (22), nun (23), samekh (24), ayin (25), pe (26), tsade (27), qof (28), resh (29), and shin (30), to tav in verse 31. In the Septuagint this poem follows chapter 29.

- e (31:21) Or, with the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses, "in double garments."
- f (31:26) Hebrew torat chesed; or "kindly instruction."
- g (31:30) Hebrew hevel, "vapor, breath," the key word of Ecclesiastes.

Ecclesiastes

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The words of Qoheleth,[a] son of David,[b] king in Jerusalem.
2 A breath of breaths,[c] says Qoheleth,
  a breath of breaths! Everything is a breath.
3 What does a person gain from all the toil
  he labors at under the sun?
4 One generation leaves and another arrives,
  yet the earth stays put forever.
5 The sun comes up and the sun goes down;
  it pants back to its place, where it rises again.
6 Blowing toward the south,
  then swinging round toward the north,
  round and round goes the wind,
  and on its rounds the wind comes back.
7 All the streams flow into the sea,
  yet the sea is never full.
  To the place where the streams flow,
  there they keep on flowing.
8 All things are wearisome,
  more than anyone can say.
  The eye never has its fill of seeing,
  nor is the ear filled up with hearing.
9 Whatever was, will be again,
  whatever was done will be done once more;
  nothing is new beneath the sun.
10 Is there a thing of which someone says,
  “Look, this is new”?
  It already existed in the ages
  that were before our time.

11 No one remembers those who came first,
and those yet to come
will not be remembered either
by the ones who come after them.
12 I, Qoheleth, was king over Israel in Jerusalem.
13 I set my mind to seek and to explore by wisdom everything that is done under the heavens. It is a grim task that God has given human beings to keep them busy.
14 I have observed everything done under the sun, and it is all vapor, like trying to catch the wind.[d]
15 What is bent no one can straighten,
and what is missing no one can number.
16 I said to myself, "Look, I have grown great and gathered more wisdom than all who ruled Jerusalem before me; my mind has taken in a wealth of wisdom and knowledge."
17 So I set my mind to understand wisdom, and to understand madness and folly.[e] I came to see that this too is a chasing after wind.
18 For with much wisdom comes much grief,
and whoever adds to knowledge adds to pain.

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew Qoheleth, a feminine participle from qahal, "assembly": one who gathers or addresses an assembly, or perhaps one who gathers sayings (12:9). It is traditionally rendered "the Preacher" or "the Teacher"; the Greek title Ekklesiastes means "member of an assembly" or "speaker in an assembly." It is kept untranslated here as the speaker's title or pen name; in 12:8 it takes the article ("the Qoheleth").
- b (1:1) David means "beloved."
- c (1:2) Hebrew hevel habalim. Hevel means "breath" or "vapor," something real but brief and impossible to grasp, and so "fleeting," "futile," or "absurd" depending on context; it is traditionally rendered "vanity" (Septuagint mataiotes). It is rendered "a breath" throughout this book so that its 38 occurrences can be traced and readers can weigh its sense in each place. "A breath of breaths" is a Hebrew superlative: "the most fleeting of breaths."
- d (1:14) Or "a feeding on wind" or "a striving after wind"; the Hebrew reʿut ruach is uncertain. The same phrase occurs in 2:11, 17, 26; 4:4, 6; 6:9.
- e (1:17) The Septuagint reads "parables and understanding" for "madness and folly."

Chapter 2

1 I said to myself, "Come on, I will test you with pleasure; enjoy what
is good." But that too turned out to be a breath. 2 Of laughter I said,
"It is mad," and of pleasure, "What does it accomplish?" 3 I searched
with my mind for a way to cheer my body with wine, while my
mind still guided me with wisdom, and a way to grasp folly, until I
could discover what is worth doing for people during their short lives
under heaven.
4 I undertook great works: houses I built for myself, vineyards I
planted for myself. 5 I made myself gardens and parks[a] and planted
every kind of fruit tree in them. 6 I made myself pools of water to
irrigate a forest of growing trees. 7 I acquired male and female slaves,
and I had slaves born in my household. I also owned more herds and
flocks than all who were before me in Jerusalem. 8 I piled up silver and
gold for myself, the treasure of kings and provinces. I got myself male
and female singers and the delights of mortals: many concubines.[b] 9
So I became great, surpassing all who were before me in Jerusalem,
and my wisdom stayed with me. 10 Whatever my eyes asked for, I did
not withhold from them. I kept no joy from my heart, for my heart
found joy in all my labor, and that was my portion from all my labor.
11 Then I turned to survey all the works my hands had made and the
labor I had put into making them, and see, it was all a breath and a
chasing after wind. There was no gain under the sun.
12 So I turned to consider wisdom, madness, and folly. For what can the
one who comes after the king do? Only what has already been done.[c]
13 I saw that wisdom has the advantage over folly, as light has the
advantage over darkness.
14 The wise have eyes in their heads,
but the fool walks in the dark.
Yet I also came to know that one fate befalls them both.
15 So I said to myself, "The fool's fate will be mine as well. Why then
have I been so very wise?" And I told myself that this too is a breath.
16 For the wise, like the fool, will not be remembered for long; in the
days to come both will long since be forgotten. How the wise die just
like fools!

17 So I came to hate life, since what is done under the sun weighed on
me as evil. For everything is a breath and a chasing after wind.
18 I hated all the toil I had toiled at under the sun, because I must leave
it to whoever comes after me. 19 And who knows whether he will be
wise or a fool? Yet he will be master of everything I worked for and
used my wisdom to gain under the sun. This too is a breath. 20 So I
turned and let my heart sink into despair over all the toil I had labored
at under the sun. 21 For here is someone whose labor was done with
wisdom, knowledge, and skill, and he must hand over his portion to
someone who did not labor for it. This too is a breath and a great evil.
22 What do people get for all their toil and the striving of their hearts
with which they labor under the sun? 23 All their days are pain, and
their work is vexation; even at night their minds find no rest. This
too is a breath.
24 There is nothing better for a person than to eat and drink and to
find good in his toil. This too, I saw, is from the hand of God. 25 For
who can eat or who can enjoy anything apart from him?[d] 26 To the
one who pleases him God gives wisdom, knowledge, and joy, but to
the sinner he assigns the business of collecting and heaping up, so
that it may be passed on to whoever is good in God's sight. This too
is a breath and a chasing after wind.

Notes

- a (2:5) Hebrew pardesim, a Persian loanword for walled parks or orchards, the source of the English word "paradise."
- b (2:8) Hebrew shiddah wesiddoth, an obscure phrase found only here; it is often taken as "many concubines," but the Septuagint reads "a butler and female cupbearers."
- c (2:12) The Hebrew of the second half is difficult; literally "What is the man who will come after the king? That which they have already done."
- d (2:25) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Masoretic Text reads "apart from me." "Enjoy" may also mean "worry" or "have sensation."

Chapter 3

1 For everything there is an appointed time,
and a season for every matter under the heavens:

2 a time to be born and a time to die,
  a time to plant and a time to pull up what was planted;
3 a time to kill and a time to heal,
  a time to tear down and a time to build up;
4 a time to weep and a time to laugh,
  a time to mourn and a time to dance;
5 a time to throw stones and a time to gather stones,[a]
  a time to embrace and a time to hold back from embracing;
6 a time to seek and a time to let go,
  a time to hold on and a time to discard;
7 a time to rip and a time to stitch,
  a time to keep silent and a time to speak;
8 a time to love and a time to hate,
  a time for war and a time for peace.
9 What does the worker gain from his toil?
10 I have seen the task God has given human beings to keep them occupied.
11 He has made everything beautiful in its time. He has also set eternity[b] in their hearts, yet in such a way that they cannot grasp what God has done from beginning to end.
12 I know that there is nothing better for them than to rejoice and to do good[c] as long as they live.
13 And also, that everyone should eat and drink and find good in all his toil: this is God's gift.
14 I know that whatever God does lasts forever. Nothing can be added to it and nothing taken from it. God has done this so that people will stand in awe of him.
15 Whatever is, has already been,
  and what will be has already been,
  and God seeks out what has been driven away.[d]
16 I also noticed something under the sun: where justice should be, there was wickedness, and where righteousness should be, there was wickedness. 17 I told myself, "God will judge both the righteous and the wicked, for there is a season for every affair and every action."[e]

18 I told myself concerning humans, “God is testing them so they will
see that they are no more than animals.” 19 For the fate of humans and
the fate of beasts is one fate. The death of one is like the death of the
other; one breath[f] is in them all. Humans have no edge over beasts,
for everything is a breath. 20 All go to one place. All come from the
dust, and to dust all return. 21 Who can say whether a human spirit
goes up while an animal’s spirit goes down to the earth?[g] 22 So I saw
that there is nothing better than for a person to rejoice in his work,
for that is his lot. For who can bring him to see what will happen
after him?

Notes

- a (3:5) The meaning of this pair is uncertain: perhaps clearing a field and building a wall, or a sexual euphemism, as the next line may suggest.
- b (3:11) Hebrew haʿolam; or “a sense of the ages” or, with a different vowel, “ignorance.”
- c (3:12) Or “to enjoy themselves.”
- d (3:15) Or “what has passed”; literally “what is pursued.”
- e (3:17) The Hebrew “there” is unexpected; some read “he has appointed” with a slight change of vowels.
- f (3:19) Hebrew ruach, “breath” or “spirit,” a different word from hevel.
- g (3:21) So the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses; the Masoretic vowels read “Who knows the spirit of humans that rises upward…?”

Chapter 4

1 Once more I surveyed all the oppression practiced under the sun.
Here are the oppressed in tears, and nobody to console them! Their
oppressors had force on their side, and nobody to console the victims.
2 So I counted the dead, who died long ago, more fortunate than the
living, who are still alive. 3 But better off than both is the one who has
never yet been, who has not seen the evil deeds done under the sun.
4 And I saw that all toil and all skillful work come from one person’s
rivalry with another. This too is a breath and a chasing after wind.
5 The fool folds his hands
and devours his own flesh.
6 Better one handful with quiet
than two fistfuls with toil and a chasing after wind.
7 Again I saw a breath under the sun:

8 There is someone all alone, with no companion, neither son nor
brother, yet his toil never ends, and his eyes never have enough of
wealth. “For whom am I toiling,” he asks, “and depriving myself of
good things?” This too is a breath, a miserable business.
9 Two are better than one,
because together they earn a good return for their toil.
10 If they fall, one can lift up his partner.
But pity the one who falls with no one to help him up!
11 Again, when two sleep side by side, they have warmth,
but one by himself, how can he get warm?
12 Where one may be overpowered, two can make a stand,
and a cord of three strands is not quickly snapped.
13 Better a poor but wise youth than an old and foolish king who no
longer knows how to take advice. 14 For the youth went from prison
to the throne, though he had been born poor in that kingdom.[a] 15 I
saw all the living who move about under the sun throng to the youth,
the second one, who would rise up in the king’s place. 16 There was
no end to all the people he led,[b] yet those who come later will not be
pleased with him. This too is a breath and a chasing after wind.

Notes

- a (4:14) The Hebrew of verses 13–16 is allusive, and it is not always clear which figure is meant by “he.”
- b (4:16) Or “all who went before them”; literally “all who were before them.”

Chapter 5

1 Watch your step[a] when you go to the house of God. To draw near
and listen is better than for fools to offer a sacrifice, for they do not
know that they are doing wrong.[b]
2 Don’t be hasty with your mouth,
or quick to speak a word in front of God.
God is in heaven and you are on earth,
so keep your words few.
3 For a dream comes with much busyness,
and a fool’s voice with many words.

4 When you vow a vow to God, do not put off paying it, for he takes
no pleasure in fools. Pay what you vow.
5 Not vowing is better than vowing and not paying.
6 Do not let your speech lead your body[c] into sin, and do not tell the
temple messenger[d] it was an accident. Why make God furious with
your words and destroy what you have worked for?
7 For with many dreams come breaths and a flood of words.[e] Rather,
fear God.
8 If you see the poor oppressed and justice and right violated in
a province, do not be astonished at the matter. For one official is
watched by a higher one, and still higher ones are over them. 9 But the
gain from the land is for all; a king is served by the cultivated field.[f]
10 Whoever loves silver is never satisfied with silver,
nor whoever loves wealth with its income.
This too is a breath.
11 When goods increase,
so do those who consume them.
And what does their owner gain
except the sight of them with his eyes?
12 Sweet is the worker's sleep,
whether he eats little or much,
but the rich man's plenty
will not let him sleep.
13 There is a sickening evil I have seen under the sun: riches hoarded
by their owner to his own harm. 14 Those riches are lost in a bad
venture, and when he fathers a son, nothing is left in his hand.[g] 15 As
he came out of his mother's womb, naked he will go back, just as he
came. He will take nothing for his toil that he can carry away in his
hand. 16 This too is a sickening evil: exactly as he came, so he will go.
What does he gain from toiling for the wind? 17 All his days he also
eats in darkness, with much vexation, sickness, and anger.[h]
18 Here is what I have seen to be good: it is fitting for a person to eat
and drink and enjoy good in all the toil he labors at beneath the sun
for the number of days God grants him to live, for that is his lot. 19
Also, everyone to whom God has given riches and possessions, and

the power to enjoy them, to accept his lot and rejoice in his toil, this is a gift of God. 20 For he will not dwell much on the days of his life, because God keeps him occupied with the joy of his heart.

Notes

- a (5:1) In Hebrew this verse is 4:17, and verses 2–20 are 5:1–19. The Ketiv reads "your feet."
- b (5:1) Or "for they do not know how to do anything but wrong."
- c (5:6) Hebrew "flesh."
- d (5:6) Probably a temple official or priest; the Septuagint reads "before God."
- e (5:7) Or "For in many dreams and many words there are breaths." The Hebrew is uncertain.
- f (5:9) The Hebrew of this verse is obscure.
- g (5:14) Hebrew 5:13–17 (English 5:14–18) is partly preserved in 4QQoh-a, the oldest known manuscript of Ecclesiastes (about 175–150 BC).
- h (5:17) The Septuagint reads "and mourning" for "he eats," a similar-looking Hebrew word.

Chapter 6

1 There is an evil I have seen under the sun, and it weighs heavily on humankind: 2 someone to whom God gives riches, possessions, and honor, so that he lacks nothing he could wish for, yet God does not give him the power to enjoy them; a stranger enjoys them instead. This is a breath and a sickening evil. 3 Suppose someone has a hundred children and lives for many years, however long his life may last, but he never enjoys his prosperity[a] and is not even buried properly; I say a stillborn baby is better off than he. 4 For it comes in a breath and departs in darkness, and in darkness its name is covered.[b] 5 It has not seen the sun or known anything, yet it has more rest than he does. 6 Even if he lived a thousand years twice over but did not enjoy good,[c] do not all go to one place?

7 All the toil of humankind is for the mouth,
yet the appetite is never filled.

8 For what advantage have the wise over fools?
What does the poor man gain by knowing how to conduct himself before the living?

9 Better what the eyes can see
than the roving of desire.
This too is a breath and a chasing after wind.
10 Whatever came into existence was named long ago, and what humanity is has been understood: no one is able to argue a case with someone stronger. 11 The more words, the more breath. What advantage is that to anyone? 12 Who knows what is good for a human being in life, during the few days of a fleeting life,[d] which passes like a shadow? Who can say what will happen on earth after he is gone?

Notes

- a (6:3) In 4QQoh-a (about 175–150 BC) the words of the opening clauses of this verse appear in a different order, without change in meaning.
- b (6:4) In 4QQoh-a the original scribe wrote "and in darkness his name is covered," referring to the man; a later scribe corrected it to agree with the Masoretic Text.
- c (6:6) 4QQoh-a uses some different words in this verse, with the same meaning.
- d (6:12) Literally "the days of the life of his breath."

Chapter 7

1 A good name is better than fine perfume,[a]
and the day of death than the day of birth.
2 Better to go to a house of mourning
than to a house of feasting,
for that is the end of everyone,
and the living should take it to heart.
3 Grief is better than laughter,
for a sad face may mean a glad heart.
4 The heart of the wise is in the house of mourning,
but the heart of fools is in the house of pleasure.
5 Better to heed the rebuke of the wise
than to listen to the song of fools.
6 For like the crackle of thorns under a pot,[b]
so is the laughter of the fool.
This too is a breath.
7 Surely extortion turns the wise into fools,
and a bribe corrupts the heart.[c]

8 The end of a thing is better than its start;
patience of spirit is better than pride of spirit.
9 Do not be quick in spirit to take offense,
for resentment lodges in the bosom of fools.
10 Do not ask, "How is it that former days were better than these?"
For it is not wisdom that prompts this question.
11 Wisdom is good together with an inheritance,
a benefit to those who see the sun.
12 For wisdom is a shelter as money is a shelter,
and the benefit of knowing is that wisdom keeps its owner alive.
13 Consider the work of God:
who can straighten what he has bent?
14 In a good day, enjoy the good,
and in a bad day, reflect:
God made this day as well as that,
so that no one can find out anything that will come after him.
15 In my fleeting days[d] I have seen both: a righteous person perishing in his righteousness, and a wicked person living long in his wickedness.
16 Do not be too righteous, and do not make yourself overly wise. Why destroy yourself?
17 Do not be too wicked, and do not play the fool. Why should you die before your time?
18 It is good to hold on to the one and not let go of the other, for whoever fears God will come through both.[e]
19 Wisdom makes the wise stronger[f]
than ten rulers in a city.
20 Surely there is no one on earth so righteous
that he does good and never sins.
21 Also, do not pay attention to everything that is said, or you may overhear your servant cursing you.
22 For your own heart knows how often you too have cursed others.
23 All this I tested by wisdom. I said, "I will be wise," but it was far from me. 24 Whatever has come to be is distant and deep, deep indeed;

who can fathom it? 25 I set my mind to know, to investigate, and to
look for wisdom and the explanation of things,[g] and to recognize the
stupidity of wickedness and the madness of folly. 26 And I find more
bitter than death the woman who is a snare, whose heart is nets and
whose hands are chains. Whoever pleases God escapes her, but the
sinner is caught by her. 27 "See, this is what I found," says Qoheleth,[h]
"adding one thing to another to find the sum, 28 which I keep searching
for but have not found: I found one upright man in a thousand, but
among all of them I found not one upright woman. 29 Only see, this I
did find: God made human beings upright, but they have sought out
many schemes."

Notes

- a (7:1) The Hebrew has a wordplay: shem, "name," and shemen, "oil" or "perfume."
- b (7:6) Another wordplay: sirim, "thorns," under the sir, "pot."
- c (7:7) Hebrew mattanah, "gift," here in the sense of a bribe. 4QQoh-a may have a different verb in the first line.
- d (7:15) Hebrew "days of my breath."
- e (7:18) Or "will avoid both extremes."
- f (7:19) So the Masoretic Text, "makes strong"; 4QQoh-a and the Septuagint read "helps."
- g (7:25) Hebrew heshbon, "account" or "reckoning," also in verse 27.
- h (7:27) The Hebrew has the verb in the feminine, "she says, Qoheleth"; dividing the letters differently gives "says the Qoheleth," as in 12:8, a reading supported by the Septuagint.

Chapter 8

1 Who is like the wise?
  Who knows how to explain a matter?
  Wisdom lights up a person's face
  and softens its hardness.[a]

2 I say:[b] obey the king's command, because of the oath you swore
before God. 3 Do not hurry to leave his presence, and do not persist
in a bad cause, for he does whatever he likes. 4 Since the king's word
is supreme, who can say to him, "What are you doing?" 5 Whoever
keeps the command will come to no harm, and a wise heart knows
the proper time and procedure. 6 For every matter has its time and
procedure, though human trouble lies heavy on a person. 7 No one

knows what is to come; who can tell anyone how it will turn out? [8]
No one has power over the wind[c] to restrain it, nor power over the
day of death. There is no discharge in wartime, and wickedness will
not rescue those who practice it.
[9] All this I observed as I applied my mind to everything done under
the sun, at a time when one person rules over another to his harm.
[10] I also saw the wicked given burial; they had come and gone from
the holy place, and people forgot[d] them in the very city where they
had acted that way. This too is vapor. [11] Because the sentence against
an evil deed is not carried out quickly, people's hearts are fully set on
doing evil. [12] A sinner may do evil a hundred times and still live long,
yet I know that it will go well with those who fear God, because they
stand in awe before him. [13] But things will not go well for the wicked,
and his days will not stretch out like an evening shadow, because he
does not fear God.
[14] There is a breath that occurs on earth: there are righteous people
who get what the deeds of the wicked deserve, and wicked people
who get what the deeds of the righteous deserve. I said that this too
is a breath. [15] So I recommend enjoyment, because nothing is better
for people under the sun than eating, drinking, and having a good
time. That will stay with them in their work during the days of life
God gives them under the sun.
[16] When I set my heart to know wisdom and to watch the business
that goes on upon the earth, even going without sleep day and night,
[17] then I saw all the work of God: no one can fathom the work that is
done under the sun. However much people strive in searching, they
will not find it out. Even if a wise person claims to know, he cannot
discover it.

Notes

- a (8:1) Literally "and the strength of his face is changed"; the Septuagint reads "but a man of shameless face will be hated."
- b (8:2) The Hebrew "I" stands alone at the start of the verse; something may have dropped out.
- c (8:8) Or "the spirit" or "the breath of life."
- d (8:10) So the Masoretic Text; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "praised," which differs by one Hebrew letter.

Chapter 9

1 I took all this to heart and tested it: that the righteous and the wise,
and all their deeds, are in God's hands. Whether love or hatred lies in
store, nobody knows; it all lies before them. 2 Everything is the same
for everyone:[a] one fate for the righteous and the wicked, the good, the
clean and the unclean, the one who sacrifices and the one who does
not. As with the good person, so with the sinner; as with the one who
swears an oath, so with the one who shrinks from swearing. 3 This is
an evil in all that is done under the sun: that one fate comes to all.
Moreover, human hearts are full of evil, and madness is in their hearts
while they live, and afterward they go to the dead. 4 But whoever is
joined[b] to all the living has hope, for a live dog is better off than a
dead lion. 5 For the living know that they will die, but the dead know
nothing. They have no more reward, for even the memory of them
is forgotten.[c] 6 Their love, their hate, and their jealousy have already
vanished, and they will never again have a share in anything done
under the sun.
7 Go, eat your bread with joy and drink your wine with a cheerful
heart, for God has already approved what you do. 8 At all times wear
white garments, and never let oil be missing from your head. 9 Enjoy
life with the wife you love throughout your fleeting life that God has
granted you under the sun, all your fleeting days,[d] since that is your
reward in life and for the labor you do beneath the sun. 10 Whatever
your hand finds to do, do it with all your strength, for there is no
work or planning or knowledge or wisdom in Sheol,[e] where you are
going.
11 Again I saw under the sun that the swift do not win the race, the
mighty do not win the battle, the wise do not always have bread, the
intelligent are not always rich, and the knowledgeable are not always
favored; time and chance meet them all. 12 Indeed, no one knows his
time. As fish are seized in an evil net and birds are gripped in a snare,
so human beings are trapped at an evil time, when it drops on them
without warning.
13 This also I saw as wisdom under the sun, and it struck me as great:

14 There was a small city with few men in it, and a great king came against it, surrounded it, and built great siegeworks against it.
15 Now in it lived a man, poor but wise, and by his wisdom he rescued the city. But no one gave a thought to that poor man.
16 So I said, "Wisdom is better than might," but the poor man's wisdom is despised, and his words go unheeded.
17 Words of the wise heard in calm
are worth more than a fool-ruler's shouting.
18 Wisdom is better than weapons of war,
but one sinner destroys much good.

Notes

- a (9:2) The Septuagint reads "Vanity is in all" at the beginning of this verse, joining the last word of verse 1 to it and reading hevel, "a breath," for hakkol, "everything."
- b (9:4) So the Qere; the Ketiv reads "chosen."
- c (9:5) A wordplay in Hebrew: sakar, "reward," and zeker, "memory."
- d (9:9) Literally "all the days of the life of your breath… all the days of your breath." The Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses lack the repeated phrase.
- e (9:10) The realm of the dead; the Septuagint has "Hades."

Chapter 10

1 Dead flies make a perfumer's oil stink and ferment;
a little folly outweighs wisdom and honor.
2 The heart of the wise leans to the right hand,
the heart of the fool to the left.[a]
3 Even as the fool walks along the road, his sense fails him,
and he shows everyone that he is a fool.
4 If the ruler's anger rises against you, do not leave your post,
for calmness lays great offenses to rest.
5 There is an evil I have seen under the sun, an error of the kind that comes from one in power:
6 folly is set in many high places, while the rich sit in lowly ones.
7 I have seen slaves on horseback and princes going on foot like slaves.
8 Whoever digs a pit may fall into it,
and whoever breaks through a wall may be bitten by a snake.
9 One who cuts stone may be injured by it,
and one who chops wood may be endangered by it.

10 When the ax is dull and its blade is left unsharpened,
one has to swing harder;
but wisdom gives the edge that succeeds.
11 If the snake bites before it is charmed,
there is no profit for the charmer.[b]
12 Words from a wise mouth win favor,
but a fool's lips swallow him up.
13 What his mouth says starts out as folly,
and what it ends with is wicked madness.
14 The fool multiplies words, though no one knows what is to come;
who can tell anyone what will happen after him?
15 A fool's toil wears him out,
for he does not even know the way to town.
16 Woe to you, O land, when your king is a lad[c]
and your officials banquet at dawn!
17 Fortunate are you, land, whose king is from a noble family
and whose officials eat at the right time,
for strength and not for drunkenness!
18 Through laziness the rafters sag,
and through idle hands the house leaks.
19 Feasts are made for laughter,
and wine cheers the living,
and money answers for everything.
20 Do not curse the king even in your private thoughts,[d]
and do not curse the wealthy even where you sleep,
for some bird of the skies will carry the sound,
some winged thing will tell the tale.

Notes

- a (10:2) The right hand stood for strength and favor, the left for weakness or misfortune.
- b (10:11) Literally "master of the tongue."
- c (10:16) Or "a servant." The Septuagint addresses a city here.
- d (10:20) Or "in your bed"; the Hebrew madda' may mean "knowledge" or, with a different reading, "bed."

Chapter 11

1 Send your bread out on the surface of the waters,
for after many days you will find it again.
2 Share a portion with seven, or even with eight,
for you cannot know what disaster may come on the earth.
3 When clouds are full,
they empty rain on the earth;
and whether a tree falls south or north,
wherever it falls, there it lies.
4 Whoever keeps watching the wind will never sow,
and whoever keeps studying the clouds will never reap.
5 As you cannot tell the way the wind[a] goes
or how the bones form in the womb of a woman with child,
so you cannot grasp what God is doing,
he who makes it all.
6 Sow your seed in the morning,
and in the evening do not rest your hand,
for you do not know which will thrive, this or that,
or whether both alike will turn out well.
7 Sweet is the light,
and it is good for the eyes to look at the sun.
8 However many years a person lives, he should take joy in each of them, while remembering that the dark days will be many. Everything still to come is a breath.
9 Rejoice, young man, while you are young;
let your heart be glad in your early years.
Walk where your heart leads
and after what your eyes behold,[b]
but know that over all these things
God will call you to account.
10 Drive grief out of your heart
and keep harm away from your flesh,
for youth and its dark hair[c] are a breath.

Notes

- a (11:5) Or “the spirit” or “the life-breath,” entering the unborn child.
- b (11:9) The Septuagint reads “walk in the ways of your heart blameless, but not in the sight of your eyes.”
- c (11:10) Hebrew shacharuth, probably “the black hair” of youth, or “the dawn.”

Chapter 12

1 Remember your Creator[a] in the days of your youth,
before the bad days come
and the years approach of which you will say,
“I have no pleasure in them”;
2 before the sun and the light,
the moon and the stars grow dark,
and the clouds return after the rain;
3 on the day when the keepers of the house shake,
and the men of strength stoop,
and the grinders cease since they are few,
and the ones who gaze through the windows are darkened;[b]
4 when the street doors are closed
and the grinding sound grows faint,
when people wake at the sound of a bird,
and all the singing girls are silenced;
5 when heights are frightening
and dangers lurk along the way;
when the almond is in flower,[c]
the locust is weighed down,
and desire fails as the caper berry[d] does;
because the human goes to his eternal home,
and the mourners go about in the street;
6 before the silver cord is snapped[e]
and the bowl of gold is cracked,
and the pitcher smashed beside the spring,
and the wheel crushed at the cistern,
7 and the dust goes back to the ground it came from,
and the life breath[f] goes back to God who gave it.
8 “A breath of breaths,” says the Qoheleth;
“everything is a breath.”

9 Besides being wise, Qoheleth also taught the people knowledge,
weighing, studying, and arranging many proverbs. 10 Qoheleth sought
to find pleasing words and to write words of truth correctly. 11 The
words of the wise are like goads, and the masters of collections are
like nails driven firmly in; one Shepherd has given them. 12 And
besides these, my son, take warning: to the making of many books
there is no end, and much poring over them exhausts the flesh.
13 The end of the matter, now that all has been heard: fear God and
keep his commandments, for this is the whole of being human.[g] 14
For God will bring every deed into judgment, including everything
hidden, whether good or evil.

Notes

- a (12:1) The Hebrew form is plural, probably a plural of majesty. Some interpreters hear a play on bor, "pit" (the grave), or be'er, "well" (one's wife, as in Proverbs 5:15–18).
- b (12:3) Verses 3–5 are often read as a picture of old age: trembling arms, bent legs, few teeth, failing eyes; or as a household in mourning.
- c (12:5) Its white blossoms are often taken as an image of white hair.
- d (12:5) Probably the caper plant, whose buds were thought to stir the appetite.
- e (12:6) So the Qere; the Ketiv reads "removed."
- f (12:7) Or "spirit," Hebrew ruach.
- g (12:13) Literally "for this is all of humanity" or "this is every person's duty."

Song of Songs

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The Song of Songs,[a] which is Solomon's.[b]
2 Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth,[c]
for your love[d] is better than wine.
3 Your oils have a pleasing scent;
your name is oil poured out.
That is why the young women love you.
4 Draw me after you; let us run!
The king has brought me into his chambers.
We will rejoice and delight in you;[e]
we will praise your love more than wine.
How right they are to love you!
5 Black am I, and lovely,
you daughters of Jerusalem,
dark as the tents of Kedar,[f]
as the hangings of Solomon.
6 Do not look down on me for being dark,
for the sun has burned me.
My brothers were furious with me;
they put me in charge of the vineyards,
but my own vineyard I neglected.
7 Tell me, my beloved,
where you pasture your flock,
where you rest them at noon?
Why should I wander like a veiled woman[g]
among your friends' flocks?
8 If you do not know, loveliest of women,
go out in the footprints of the sheep

and feed your kids
near the tents of the shepherds.[h]
9 To a mare among Pharaoh's chariots
I compare you, my darling.[i]
10 Lovely are your cheeks between the earrings,
your neck among the beads.
11 Earrings of gold we will make for you,
dotted with silver.[j]
12 While the king lay on his couch,
my nard[k] spread out its scent.
13 My beloved is to me a sachet of myrrh[l]
that lies all night between my breasts.
14 My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms[m]
in the vineyards of En-gedi.[n]
15 Look at you, my darling, so beautiful,
so beautiful! Your eyes are doves.[o]
16 How handsome you are, my beloved, how delightful![p]
Our couch is green and leafy;
17 the beams of our house are cedars,
our rafters are junipers.[q]

Notes

- a (1:1) A Hebrew way of saying "the finest song."
- b (1:1) Or "for Solomon" or "about Solomon." The name Shelomoh is connected with shalom, "peace."
- c (1:2) She speaks in verses 2–4, turning from "him" to "you." The Hebrew has no speaker labels; here and below they are inferred from the grammar.
- d (1:2) Hebrew dodim, "lovemaking" or "caresses"; also in verse 4. The Septuagint, reading the same letters differently, has "your breasts."
- e (1:4) The plural "we" may be the young women of verse 3 or the friends; "you" is masculine.
- f (1:5) Kedar, a tribe of the Syrian–Arabian desert, whose name may mean "dark"; their tents were woven of black goat hair.
- g (1:7) Perhaps veiled as a prostitute (compare Genesis 38:14–15); some ancient witnesses read "one who wanders."
- h (1:8) He replies in verse 8, or perhaps the friends.

- i (1:9) He speaks in verses 9–11. Hebrew raʿyati, “my companion,” his usual word for her in the Song. A mare loosed among chariot stallions was a famous image of distraction.
- j (1:11) The “we” here may be his companions or the friends.
- k (1:12) She speaks in verses 12–14. Nard, or spikenard, a costly perfume from a plant of the Himalayas.
- l (1:13) Myrrh, a fragrant resin from trees of Arabia and East Africa, worn in a small pouch.
- m (1:14) Henna, a shrub with fragrant clusters of white flowers, also used for dye.
- n (1:14) En-gedi, “spring of the young goat,” an oasis on the western shore of the Dead Sea.
- o (1:15) He speaks.
- p (1:16) She speaks in verses 16–17; some divide verse 17 between them.
- q (1:17) Or “firs” or “cypresses”; the exact tree is uncertain.

Chapter 2

1 I am a crocus[a] of Sharon,[b]
  a lily of the valleys.
2 As a lily among the brambles,
  so is my darling among the girls.[c]
3 Like an apple tree[d] among the trees of the forest,
  so is my beloved among the young men.[e]
  In his shade I delight to sit,
  and his fruit is sweet to my taste.
4 He has brought me to the house of wine,
  and his banner over me is love.
5 Revive me with raisin cakes,
  refresh me with apples,
  for I am faint with love.
6 His left hand is under my head,
  and his right hand embraces me.
7 I put you under oath, daughters of Jerusalem,
  by the gazelles, by the wild does:
  do not rouse, do not wake love
  until it wishes![f]
8 Hark! My beloved!
  See, he is coming,

springing across the mountains,
bounding over the hills.
9 My beloved is like a gazelle
or a fawn of the deer.
There he is, standing outside our wall,
looking in at the windows,
glancing through the latticework.
10 My beloved answers me and says,
"Up, my darling,
my beautiful one, come away,
11 for look, the winter is past;
the rain has ended and gone.
12 Blossoms appear in the land,
the season of singing[g] has come,
and the cooing of the turtledove
is heard in our land.
13 The fig tree ripens its early figs,
and the vines in bloom give off fragrance.
Arise, my darling,
my beautiful one, and come away.
14 My dove in the clefts of the rock,
in the hiding places of the cliff,
show me your form,
let your voice be heard,
for sweet is the sound of you
and lovely the sight of you."
15 Seize the foxes for us,[h]
those little foxes
that spoil the vineyards
now that our vines are blossoming.
16 My beloved is mine and I am his;
he grazes among the lilies.
17 Until the day breathes
and the shadows slip away,
come back, my beloved, like a gazelle

or a fawn of the deer
on the cleft mountains.[i]

Notes

- a (2:1) She speaks. The flower is uncertain: crocus, narcissus, or some other meadow flower; the Septuagint has "a flower of the plain."
- b (2:1) Sharon, the coastal plain south of Mount Carmel, known for its pastures and wildflowers; the name means "plain."
- c (2:2) He speaks.
- d (2:3) Hebrew tappuach, perhaps the apple, apricot, or quince.
- e (2:3) She speaks in verses 3–17.
- f (2:7) A wordplay: tsevaoth, "gazelles," and 'ayloth hassadeh, "does of the field," sound like the divine titles "Yahweh of hosts" and "God Almighty" (El Shaddai), as though she swears by them in a veiled way. The Septuagint reads "by the powers and by the virtues of the field." The refrain returns in 3:5 and 8:4.
- g (2:12) Or "pruning," as in the Septuagint; Hebrew zamir can mean either.
- h (2:15) The speaker of verse 15 is uncertain; perhaps she quotes a song, or her brothers speak (compare 1:6).
- i (2:17) Or "the mountains of Bether," an unknown place, or "the mountains of spices" (compare 8:14). The Septuagint has "the mountains of the ravines."

Chapter 3

1 On my bed, night after night,[a]
I sought the one my soul loves;
I sought him but did not find him.
2 "I will rise now and go around the city,
through the streets and the squares;
I will seek the one my soul loves."
I sought him but did not find him.
3 The watchmen came upon me,
those who patrol the city.
"The one my soul loves: have you seen him?"
4 I had barely left them
when I met the man I love.
I grabbed him and refused to release him
until I brought him to my mother's home,
to the chamber of the woman who bore me.
5 I put you under oath, daughters of Jerusalem,
by the gazelles, by the wild does:

do not rouse, do not wake love
until it wishes!
6 Who is this coming up from the wilderness[b]
like columns of smoke,
perfumed with myrrh and frankincense,[c]
with all the powders of the merchant?
7 Look, it is Solomon's litter!
Sixty warriors surround it,
from the warriors of Israel,
8 all of them gripping swords,
trained in battle,
each with his sword at his thigh
against the terrors of the night.
9 King Solomon made himself a carriage[d]
of wood from Lebanon.[e]
10 Its posts he made of silver,
its back of gold,
its seat of purple wool,
its interior inlaid with love[f]
by the daughters of Jerusalem.
11 Come out, women of Zion,
and look at King Solomon
in the crown his mother set on him
at his wedding,
on the day his heart was glad.

Notes

- a (3:1) She speaks in verses 1–5. Literally "in the nights."
- b (3:6) The speaker of verses 6–11 is unstated: perhaps the friends or a narrator. "Who is this" is feminine in Hebrew, referring to the litter or to the bride.
- c (3:6) Frankincense, a white resin from trees of southern Arabia and Somalia, burned as incense.
- d (3:9) Hebrew 'appiryon, found only here, perhaps a loanword from Persian or Greek for a palanquin or sedan chair.
- e (3:9) Lebanon, "white," from its snowcapped peaks, famous for its cedars.
- f (3:10) Or "inlaid with leather," by a related Semitic word; the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 4

1 Look at you, my darling, so lovely,[a]
so lovely!
Doves are your eyes
behind your veil.
Your hair is a flock of goats
streaming down the slopes of Gilead.[b]
2 Your teeth are like a flock of shorn ewes
come up from the washing,
every one of them bearing twins,
and none among them bereaved.
3 A scarlet ribbon, those lips of yours,
and lovely is your mouth.
Like a half of pomegranate
is your temple behind your veil.
4 Your neck is like the tower of David,
built in courses,[c]
with a thousand shields hung on it,
all the round shields of warriors.
5 Your breasts are two fawns,
a gazelle's twins,
grazing among the lilies.
6 Until the day breathes
and the shadows slip away,
I will go to the mountain of myrrh
and to the hill of frankincense.
7 You are beautiful through and through, my darling;
there is no flaw in you.
8 Come with me from Lebanon, my bride,[d]
come with me from Lebanon!
Descend from the peak of Amana,
from the summits of Senir and Hermon,[e]
from the dens of lions,
from the mountains of leopards.

9 You have made my heart race, my sister,[f] my bride;
you have made my heart race with one look from your eyes,
with one bead of your necklace.
10 How fine is your love, my sister, my bride!
How much better your love than wine,
and the scent of your oils than any spice!
11 Your lips drop honeycomb, my bride;
honey and milk lie beneath your tongue,
and your clothing smells like the cedars of Lebanon.
12 A garden locked up is my sister, my bride,
a spring[g] locked up, a fountain sealed.
13 Your shoots are an orchard[h] of pomegranates
with choicest fruits,
henna with nard,
14 nard and saffron,[i]
calamus[j] and cinnamon,
with every tree of frankincense,
myrrh and aloes,[k]
with all the finest spices.
15 You are a fountain in the gardens,
a well of living water,
streams flowing down from Lebanon.
16 Wake up, north wind;
come, south wind![l]
Blow on my garden,
let its spices flow out.
Let my beloved come into his garden
and eat its choicest fruits.

Notes

- a (4:1) He speaks in verses 1–15.
- b (4:1) Gilead, the hill country east of the Jordan, known for its pastures; the name may mean "heap of witness" (compare Genesis 31:47–48).
- c (4:4) Hebrew talpiyyoth, found only here; the meaning is uncertain: perhaps "in courses of stone," "for weapons," or "as a landmark."
- d (4:8) The Septuagint reads "Come from Lebanon, my bride." The Hebrew "with me" may be read with a slight change of vowels as "come."

- e (4:8) Amana, a peak in the Anti-Lebanon range; Senir, the Amorite name for Hermon (Deuteronomy 3:9), or a nearby peak. Hermon, the highest mountain of the region, about 9,200 feet (2,814 meters).
- f (4:9) "Sister" was a term of endearment for a beloved or bride in ancient Near Eastern love poetry; it does not imply kinship.
- g (4:12) Hebrew gal, perhaps "pool" or "spring"; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read gan, "garden," repeating the first line.
- h (4:13) Hebrew pardes, "park" or "orchard" (compare Ecclesiastes 2:5).
- i (4:14) Saffron, the dried stigmas of the crocus, used as a spice and dye.
- j (4:14) Calamus, a fragrant reed or cane imported from the east (compare Exodus 30:23).
- k (4:14) Aloes here means eaglewood, a fragrant Asian wood, not the medicinal aloe plant.
- l (4:16) She speaks in verse 16.

Chapter 5

1 I have come into my garden, my sister, my bride;[a]
I have gathered my myrrh with my spice;
I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey;
I have drunk my wine with my milk.
Eat, friends, and drink;
drink deep, lovers![b]
2 I slept, but my heart kept watch.[c]
Listen! My beloved knocks:
"Let me in, my sister, my darling,
my dove, my flawless one,
for my head is soaked with dew,
my curls with the night's moisture."
3 "I have removed my dress;
should I dress again?
I have washed my feet;
should I soil them?"
4 My beloved thrust his hand through the opening,[d]
and my insides stirred for him.
5 I got up to open to my beloved,
and my hands dripped with myrrh,

my fingers with liquid myrrh,
on the handles of the bolt.
6 I opened to my beloved,
but my beloved had turned and gone.
My soul went out of me when he spoke.[e]
I searched for him but could not find him;
I called him, but he gave no answer.
7 The watchmen who go around the city found me;
they struck me, they bruised me;
the guards of the walls
took my shawl from me.
8 I put you under oath, daughters of Jerusalem:
if you find my beloved,
what will you tell him?
That I am faint with love!
9 What makes your beloved better than any other,[f]
most beautiful of women?
What makes your beloved better than any other,
that you put us under oath like this?
10 My beloved is dazzling and ruddy,[g]
one who stands out among ten thousand.
11 His head is finest gold;
his hair is in curls,[h]
black as a raven.
12 His eyes are doves
by the water brooks,
washed in milk,
sitting in their settings.[i]
13 His cheeks are like beds of spice,
towers of perfumes.[j]
His lips are lilies
dripping liquid myrrh.
14 His arms are rods of gold
set with jewels of Tarshish.[k]

His body is a panel of ivory
covered with lapis lazuli.[l]
15 His legs are marble columns
resting on golden bases.
He looks as majestic as Lebanon,
as stately as cedar trees.
16 His mouth is utter sweetness;
he is wholly desirable.
Such is my lover, such is my friend,
women of Jerusalem.

Notes

- a (5:1) He speaks in the first four lines.
- b (5:1) Or "drink deep of love." The speaker of these two lines is uncertain: the friends, a narrator, or he himself.
- c (5:2) She speaks in verses 2–8, recounting a dream-like night; he speaks in verse 2 and she answers in verse 3.
- d (5:4) Literally "through the hole," probably the keyhole or latch opening of the door.
- e (5:6) Or "when he turned away"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- f (5:9) The daughters of Jerusalem speak in verse 9.
- g (5:10) She answers in verses 10–16. Hebrew tsach, "radiant" or "shining."
- h (5:11) Hebrew taltallim, found only here, perhaps "like palm fronds" or "curly."
- i (5:12) Or "sitting by brimming pools"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (5:13) So the Masoretic Text; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read "pouring out perfumes," with a change of vowels.
- k (5:14) Tarshish, a distant port, perhaps in Spain; here probably a gemstone named for it, such as beryl or topaz.
- l (5:14) Literally "sapphires"; the ancient stone of that name was probably lapis lazuli.

Chapter 6

1 Where did your beloved go,[a]
loveliest among women?
In what direction did your beloved turn,
that we may seek him along with you?
2 My beloved has gone down to his garden,[b]
to the beds of spice,

to graze in the gardens
and to gather lilies.
3 I am my beloved's and my beloved is mine;
he grazes among the lilies.
4 You are beautiful, my darling, as Tirzah,[c]
lovely as Jerusalem,
awe-inspiring as an army under banners.[d]
5 Turn your eyes away from me,
for they overwhelm me.
Your hair is a flock of goats
streaming down from Gilead.
6 Your teeth are a flock of ewes
come up from the washing,
every one of them bearing twins,
and none among them bereaved.
7 Like a half of pomegranate
is your temple behind your veil.
8 There may be sixty queens
and eighty concubines,
and young women past counting,
9 but my dove, my flawless one, is matchless,
her mother's only daughter,
the pride of the woman who bore her.
Young women saw her and declared her happy;
queens and concubines sang her praise:
10 "Who is she, gazing out like the morning,
lovely as the moon,[e]
radiant as the sun,
formidable as an army with banners?"
11 I went down to the nut grove[f]
to see the new growth of the valley,
to see whether the vine had budded
and the pomegranates were in bloom.
12 Before I knew it, my desire set me
among the chariots of my noble people.[g]

13 Turn around, turn around, O Shulammite![h]
Turn around, turn around, and let us look at you!
Why would you look at the Shulammite
as at the dance of the two camps?[i]

Notes

- a (6:1) The daughters of Jerusalem speak in verse 1.
- b (6:2) She speaks in verses 2–3.
- c (6:4) He speaks in verses 4–10. Tirzah, "she is pleasing," was a beautiful city and early royal capital of the northern kingdom (1 Kings 14:17; 16:23); the Septuagint translates the name as "Pleasure."
- d (6:4) Or "as the starry hosts"; the Hebrew nidgaloth is uncertain. Also in verse 10.
- e (6:10) The poetic words here are levanah, "the white one," for the moon, and chammah, "the hot one," for the sun.
- f (6:11) The speaker of verses 11–12 is uncertain, probably she, possibly he.
- g (6:12) Or "among the chariots of Amminadib," as a name, "my kinsman is noble"; the Septuagint has "the chariots of Aminadab." The Hebrew of this verse is among the most obscure in the book.
- h (6:13) In Hebrew this verse is 7:1, and 7:1–13 below are Hebrew 7:2–14. The friends call to her in the first two lines; she, or he, answers in the last two. Shulammite may mean "woman of Shulem" (perhaps Shunem, as in the Septuagint), or be a feminine form linked with Solomon and shalom, "the peaceful one."
- i (6:13) Or "the dance of Mahanaim," a town east of the Jordan whose name means "two camps" (Genesis 32:2).

Chapter 7

1 How beautiful your feet in sandals,[a]
O noble daughter![b]
The curves of your thighs are like jewelry,
the work of a master's hands.
2 Your navel is a round goblet
that never runs short of spiced wine.
Your waist is a mound of wheat
hedged about with lilies.
3 Your two breasts are like two fawns,
twins of a gazelle.
4 Your neck is like an ivory tower.
Your eyes are pools in Heshbon[c]
beside the gate of Bath-rabbim.[d]

Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon
that looks out toward Damascus.
5 Your head sits on you like Carmel,[e]
your loose hair gleams like purple;[f]
a king is caught in their tresses.
6 How lovely you are, how delightful,
love, among all delights![g]
7 This stature of yours is like a palm tree,
and your breasts are its clusters.
8 I said, "I will climb the palm tree;
I will take hold of its fruit stalks."
May your breasts be like clusters of the vine,
the scent of your breath like apples,
9 and your mouth like the best wine
flowing smoothly for my beloved,[h]
gliding over the lips of sleepers.[i]
10 I am my beloved's,
and his desire is for me.
11 Come, my beloved,
let us go out to the countryside;
let us spend the night among the henna bushes.[j]
12 Let us go early to the vineyards
to see whether the vine has budded,
whether its blossoms have opened
and the pomegranates are in flower.
There I will give you my love.
13 The mandrakes[k] breathe out their scent,
and at our doors are all the finest fruits,
fresh ones and stored ones,
that I have laid up for you, my beloved.

Notes

- a (7:1) He speaks in verses 1–9a, or the friends in verses 1–5. English 7:1–13 is Hebrew 7:2–14.
- b (7:1) Literally "daughter of a noble" or "prince's daughter."

- c (7:4) Heshbon, “reckoning,” a city east of the Jordan, in what is now Jordan, known for its reservoirs.
- d (7:4) Bath-rabbim, “daughter of many,” probably the name of a city gate.
- e (7:5) Carmel, “garden land” or “orchard,” the wooded ridge rising above the Mediterranean near modern Haifa.
- f (7:5) Purple dye, from the murex shell, was the costliest color in the ancient world.
- g (7:6) Or “O loved one, daughter of delights,” following some ancient witnesses with a different division of the Hebrew letters.
- h (7:9) She takes up his words in the last two lines and speaks in verses 10–13.
- i (7:9) So the Masoretic Text; the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses read “over my lips and teeth.”
- j (7:11) Or “in the villages”; Hebrew kefarim can mean either.
- k (7:13) Mandrakes, a plant with a fragrant yellow fruit, thought to stir love and fertility (compare Genesis 30:14–16).

Chapter 8

1 Oh, that you were like my own brother,[a]
one suckled at my mother’s breast!
Then if I met you outside, I could kiss you,
and no one would think less of me.
2 I would guide you and bring you
to my mother’s home, where she would instruct me.[b]
I would give you spiced wine to drink,
the nectar of my pomegranates.
3 His left hand is under my head,
and his right hand embraces me.
4 I put you under oath, daughters of Jerusalem:
why rouse, why wake love
until it wishes?[c]
5 Who is this coming up from the wilderness,[d]
leaning on her beloved?
Under the apple tree I roused you;[e]
there your mother went into labor with you,
there she who bore you was in labor.
6 Set me as a seal over your heart,
as a seal on your arm,
for love is as fierce as death,

its passion[f] as unyielding as Sheol.
Its flashes are flashes of fire,
a flame of Yah.[g]
7 Many waters cannot put out love,
and rivers will not sweep it away.
If someone offered all the wealth of his house for love,
he would be utterly scorned.
8 We have a little sister,[h]
and she has no breasts yet.
What shall we do for our sister
on the day she is spoken for?
9 If she is a wall,
we will build on her a parapet of silver;
but if she is a door,
we will board her up with planks of cedar.
10 I was a wall,[i]
and my breasts were like towers.
So in his eyes I became
like one who finds peace.[j]
11 Solomon had a vineyard at Baal-hamon;[k]
he let the vineyard out to keepers.
For its fruit each one owed him
twenty-five pounds of silver.[l]
12 My vineyard, my very own, is mine to give.
The twenty-five pounds are yours, Solomon,
and five pounds[m] for those who tend its fruit.
13 You who dwell in the gardens,[n]
friends are attentive to your voice;
let me be the one to hear it!
14 Hurry away, my beloved,[o]
and be like a gazelle
or a fawn of the deer
on the mountains of spices.

Notes

- a (8:1) She speaks in verses 1–4.

- b (8:2) Or, with the Septuagint and some other ancient witnesses, “into the room of the one who conceived me” (compare 3:4).
- c (8:4) The refrain of 2:7 and 3:5, here without the oath by gazelles and does, and phrased as a question.
- d (8:5) The friends speak in the first two lines.
- e (8:5) She speaks in verses 5b–7. In the Hebrew, “you” in this verse is masculine. The Septuagint begins this verse “Who is this that comes up all white.”
- f (8:6) Or “jealousy,” Hebrew qin’ah, the intense ardor of love.
- g (8:6) Hebrew shalhevetyah. The ending -yah may be the short form of the divine name, “a flame of Yahweh,” or it may simply intensify the word, “a mighty flame,” as Hebrew sometimes uses divine names for a superlative. This is the only possible mention of God in the Song.
- h (8:8) Her brothers speak in verses 8–9 (compare 1:6).
- i (8:10) She speaks in verses 10–12.
- j (8:10) Hebrew shalom, perhaps a wordplay on Solomon (Shelomoh) and the Shulammite (6:13).
- k (8:11) Baal-hamon, “owner of abundance” or “lord of a multitude,” an unknown place; the name may be symbolic.
- l (8:11) Hebrew “a thousand of silver,” that is, a thousand shekels, about 11.5 kilograms.
- m (8:12) Hebrew “two hundred,” that is, two hundred shekels of silver, about 2.3 kilograms.
- n (8:13) He speaks in verse 13; “you” is feminine.
- o (8:14) She speaks in verse 14 (compare 2:17).

Isaiah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The vision of Isaiah the son of Amoz, which he saw concerning
Judah and Jerusalem in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and
Hezekiah, kings of Judah.[a]
2 Hear, O heavens, and give ear, O earth,
for Yahweh has spoken:
"I have nourished and brought up children,
and they have rebelled against me.
3 The ox knows his owner,
and the donkey the manger of its lord;
Israel has not known,
my people have not understood."
4 Ah, sinful nation,
a people heavy with iniquity,
offspring of evildoers,
children who deal corruptly!
They have forsaken Yahweh,
they have despised the Holy One of Israel,
they have turned away backward.[b]
5 Why will you still be struck,
that you revolt more and more?
The whole head is sick,
and the whole heart faint.
6 From the sole of the foot even to the head
there is no soundness in it,
but wounds and bruises and fresh sores;
they have not been pressed out, nor bound up,
nor softened with oil.

7 Your country is desolate,
your cities are burned with fire;
your land, strangers devour it in your presence,
and it is desolate, as overthrown by strangers.[c]
8 Zion's daughter remains like a lean-to in a vineyard,
like a watchman's hut in a melon patch,
like a town under blockade.[d]
9 Unless Yahweh of Armies had left to us a small remnant,
we would have been as Sodom,
we would have been like Gomorrah.[e]
10 Hear the word of Yahweh,
you rulers of Sodom;
give ear to the law of our God,
you people of Gomorrah![f]
11 "What to me is the multitude of your sacrifices?" says Yahweh.
"I have had my fill of burnt offerings of rams
and the fat of fed beasts;
and I take no delight in the blood of bulls,
or of lambs, or of he-goats.
12 When you come to stand in front of me,
who asked this of you,
this trampling of my courts?
13 Bring no more vain offerings;
incense is an abomination to me.
New moon and sabbath, the calling of assemblies—
I cannot endure iniquity along with the solemn meeting.
14 Your new moons and your appointed feasts my soul hates;
they are a burden to me;
I am weary of bearing them.
15 And when you spread forth your hands,
I will hide my eyes from you;
yes, when you make many prayers, I will not hear;
your hands are full of blood.[g]

16 Wash yourselves, make yourselves clean;
put away the evil of your doings from before my eyes;
cease to do evil;
17 learn to do good;
seek justice, set right the oppressor;
judge the fatherless, plead for the widow."[h]
18 "Come now, and let us reason together," says Yahweh:
"Though your sins are as scarlet,
they shall be as white as snow;
though they are red like crimson,
they shall be as wool.[i]
19 If you consent and listen,
the best of the land you shall eat;
20 but if you refuse and are rebellious,
by the sword you shall be eaten;
for the mouth of Yahweh has spoken."
21 How the faithful city has become a harlot!
She that was full of justice!
Righteousness lodged in her,
but now murderers.
22 Your silver has become dross,
your wine mixed with water.
23 Your rulers are rebels
and partners of thieves.
Every one of them loves bribes
and chases after payoffs.
They do not defend the orphan,
and the widow's case never reaches them.
24 Therefore says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
the Mighty One of Israel:[j]
"Ah, I will ease myself of my adversaries,
and avenge myself on my enemies.
25 And I will bring my hand back upon you,
and refine your dross as with lye,
and will take away all your alloy.[k]

26 I will bring back your judges as they were at first,
and your advisers as they were in the beginning.
After that you will be called the City of Righteousness,
the Faithful City."
27 Zion shall be redeemed with justice,
and her returning ones with righteousness.[l]
28 But the crushing of transgressors and sinners shall be together,
and those who forsake Yahweh shall be consumed.
29 You will be ashamed of the oak trees you wanted,
and embarrassed by the gardens you chose.[m]
30 For you shall be as an oak whose leaf withers,
and as a garden that has no water.
31 The strong person will become kindling,
his work a spark;
both will burn together,
and no one will put them out.[n]

Notes

- a (1:1) Isaiah, Hebrew Yesha'yahu, "Yahweh is salvation"; Amoz, "strong" (not the prophet Amos, a different name in Hebrew). Uzziah, "my strength is Yahweh"; Jotham, "Yahweh is perfect"; Ahaz, "he has grasped"; Hezekiah, "Yahweh strengthens." Their reigns span about 790–686 BC; Uzziah died about 740 BC (6:1). Judah, perhaps "praised"; Jerusalem, perhaps "foundation of Shalem (peace)."
- b (1:4) The Holy One of Israel, Isaiah's characteristic title for God (about twenty-five times in the book). Israel, "God strives" or "he strives with God."
- c (1:7) Hebrew "as the overthrow of strangers"; some propose "as the overthrow of Sodom" (sedom for zarim), compare verses 9–10. The Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa-a) adds "upon it."
- d (1:8) Zion, the hill of Jerusalem, meaning uncertain (perhaps "fortress"); "daughter of Zion" personifies the city. The cucumber field's lodge was a watchman's hut.
- e (1:9) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." Tseva'ot means "armies" or "hosts," whether the armies of Israel, the stars, or the heavenly beings; the title presents Yahweh as commander of every power in heaven and earth. Sodom and Gomorrah, the cities destroyed in Genesis 19; meanings uncertain. Compare Romans 9:29.
- f (1:10) Or "instruction" (torah), here prophetic teaching.
- g (1:15) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "your fingers with iniquity" (compare 59:3).
- h (1:17) Or "correct the ruthless"; the Septuagint reads "deliver him that is suffering wrong." The Hebrew hamots is uncertain.

- i (1:18) Or “Though your sins are as scarlet, shall they be white as snow?” The Hebrew may be read as a question.
- j (1:24) Hebrew ha’adon, “the Lord” (the master). “Mighty One of Israel,” Hebrew ’avir yisra’el; compare Genesis 49:24 (“Mighty One of Jacob”).
- k (1:25) Or “purge away … as with potash.” Alloy, or “tin” or “lead,” the base metals separated in refining.
- l (1:27) Or “her repentant ones.”
- m (1:29) The oaks (or terebinths) and gardens were sites of the fertility cults.
- n (1:31) Or “the strong man”; or, with a change of vowels, “your strength” (so the Great Isaiah Scroll, “your strength … your work”).

Chapter 2

1 The word that Isaiah the son of Amoz saw concerning Judah and
Jerusalem.
2 And it shall come to pass in the latter days
that the mountain of the house of Yahweh
shall be established at the top of the mountains,
and shall be exalted above the hills;
and all the nations shall stream to it.[a]
3 And many peoples shall go and say,
“Come, and let us go up to the mountain of Yahweh,
to the house of the God of Jacob;
and he will teach us from his ways,
and we will walk in his paths.”
For the law shall go out from Zion,
and the word of Yahweh from Jerusalem.[b]
4 He will settle disputes among the nations
and arbitrate for many peoples;
they will hammer their swords into plowshares
and their spears into pruning knives;
one nation will not raise a sword against another,
and they will never train for war again.
5 House of Jacob, come,
let us walk in Yahweh’s light.
6 For you have forsaken your people, the house of Jacob,
because they are filled with customs from the east,

and are soothsayers like the Philistines,
and they strike hands with the children of foreigners.[c]
7 Their land also is full of silver and gold,
and there is no end of their treasures;
their land also is full of horses,
and there is no end of their chariots.
8 Their land also is full of idols;
they worship the work of their own hands,
that which their own fingers have made.[d]
9 And man is bowed down,
and each one is brought low;
and do not forgive them![e]
10 Enter into the rock,
and hide in the dust,
from before the terror of Yahweh,
and from the splendor of his majesty.[f]
11 The lofty looks of man shall be brought low,
and the haughtiness of men shall be bowed down,
and Yahweh alone shall be exalted in that day.
12 For Yahweh of Armies has a day
against all that is proud and lofty,
and against all that is lifted up, and it shall be brought low;
13 and against all the cedars of Lebanon,
that are high and lifted up,
and against all the oaks of Bashan;[g]
14 and against all the high mountains,
and against all the hills that are lifted up;
15 and against every lofty tower,
and against every wall made strong;
16 and against all the ships of Tarshish,
and against all the pleasant craft.[h]
17 And the loftiness of man shall be bowed down,
and the haughtiness of men shall be brought low;
and Yahweh alone shall be exalted in that day.
18 And the idols shall utterly pass away.

19 And men shall go into the caves of the rocks,
and into the holes of the earth,
from before the terror of Yahweh,
and from the splendor of his majesty,
when he arises to shake the earth with terror.
20 In that day men shall cast away their idols of silver
and their idols of gold,
which they made for themselves to worship,
to the moles and to the bats;[i]
21 to go into the clefts of the rocks,
and into the crevices of the crags,
from before the terror of Yahweh,
and from the splendor of his majesty,
when he arises to shake the earth with terror.
22 Stop trusting in man, who has but breath in his nostrils;
for at what is he to be valued?[j]

Notes

- a (2:2) Verses 2–4 appear also, with small differences, at Micah 4:1–3.
- b (2:3) Jacob, "he grasps the heel" or "he supplants," here the people descended from him. Or "instruction."
- c (2:6) Hebrew "they are filled from the east"; perhaps "filled with diviners from the east" (one word may have dropped out). Philistines, the people of the southern coastal plain. "Strike hands," that is, make pacts or bargains.
- d (2:8) Hebrew 'elilim, a scornful word for idols, sounding like 'elohim ("God") and meaning "nothings" or "worthless things."
- e (2:9) Or "and you cannot raise them up." The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks this last line ("and do not forgive them") and all of verse 10; the Septuagint has both.
- f (2:10) Compare Revelation 6:15–16.
- g (2:13) Lebanon, "white," the snow-capped mountain range north of Israel; Bashan, the fertile highlands east of the Sea of Galilee.
- h (2:16) Tarshish, a distant port in the west, perhaps Tartessus in Spain; "ships of Tarshish" were large seagoing ships. "Pleasant craft," a rare Hebrew word, perhaps "beautiful vessels"; the Septuagint reads "every ship of the sea, and … every display of fine ships."
- i (2:20) Hebrew "to the dig-rats" (lahpor peroth), a word or words of uncertain meaning, probably moles or shrews; the Great Isaiah Scroll writes it as one word.
- j (2:22) The Septuagint lacks this verse; the Great Isaiah Scroll has it.

Chapter 3

1 For behold, the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
takes away from Jerusalem and from Judah
support and supply,
all the support of bread,
and all the support of water;[a]
2 the warrior and the man of battle,
judge and prophet,
diviner and elder,
3 the commander of fifty and the man held in honor,
the counselor and the one wise in crafts,
and the one skilled in enchantment.
4 And I will give boys to be their princes,
and capricious ones shall rule over them.[b]
5 And the people shall oppress one another,
man against man, and each against his neighbor;
the youth shall behave himself proudly against the old man,
and the base against the honorable.
6 A man will seize his brother in his father's house, saying,
"You have a coat; you be our leader,
and take charge of this heap of ruins"—
7 in that day he shall lift up his voice, saying,
"I will not be a binder of wounds;
for in my house is neither bread nor cloak;
you shall not make me ruler of the people."
8 For Jerusalem has stumbled, and Judah has fallen,
because their tongue and their doings are against Yahweh,
to defy the eyes of his glory.[c]
9 Their very expressions accuse them,
and they announce their sin like Sodom;
they do not conceal it.
How terrible for them!
They have done harm to themselves.

10 Say of the righteous that it shall be well with him,
for they shall eat the fruit of their deeds.
11 Woe to the wicked man! Evil is his lot;
for the dealing of his own hands shall be rendered to him.[d]
12 My people are oppressed by children,
and women rule over them.
My people, your guides lead you astray
and confuse the path you walk.[e]
13 Yahweh stands up to plead,
and stands to judge the peoples.[f]
14 Yahweh will enter into judgment
with the elders of his people and their princes:
"It is you who have eaten up the vineyard;
the spoil of the poor is in your houses.
15 How dare you crush my people
and grind down the faces of the poor?"
says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies.
16 Moreover Yahweh said:
"Because the daughters of Zion are proud,
and go about with necks stretched out
and glancing eyes,
tripping along as they walk,
and jingling with their feet;
17 therefore the Lord will afflict with scabs
the heads of Zion's daughters,
and Yahweh will lay bare their secret parts."[g]
18 In that day the Lord will take away the finery of the anklets, and the headbands, and the crescents;[h]
19 the pendants, and the bracelets, and the veils;
20 the headdresses, and the ankle chains, and the sashes, and the perfume boxes, and the amulets;
21 the rings, and the nose jewels;
22 the festal robes, and the mantles, and the shawls, and the purses;
23 the mirrors, and the fine linen, and the turbans, and the veils.

24 Then instead of perfume there will be a stench;
instead of a sash, a rope;
instead of styled hair, baldness;
instead of fine clothing, sackcloth;
and a brand instead of beauty.[i]
25 Your men shall fall by the sword,
and your mighty ones in the war.
26 And her gates shall lament and mourn;
and she, emptied, shall sit upon the ground.

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew ha'adon, "the Lord." "Support and supply," Hebrew mash'en umash'enah, masculine and feminine forms of one word: "every kind of support."
- b (3:4) Or "infants" or "wanton tyranny." The Hebrew ta'alulim is uncertain.
- c (3:8) Or "to rebel against his glorious presence."
- d (3:11) Hebrew "the dealing of his hands"; the Great Isaiah Scroll reads "shall return to him."
- e (3:12) The Septuagint reads "your exactors strip you, and extortioners rule over you," perhaps taking the Hebrew as nosim ("creditors") instead of nashim ("women"). "Swallow up," or "confuse."
- f (3:13) The Septuagint reads "his people"; Hebrew "peoples."
- g (3:17) Or "their foreheads"; the Hebrew poth is uncertain. In verses 17–18 the Great Isaiah Scroll interchanges 'Adonai ("Lord") and Yahweh, with scribal corrections above the line.
- h (3:18) Many of the items in verses 18–23 are rare words whose exact sense is uncertain.
- i (3:24) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds a word: "for instead of beauty, shame." "Branding" (ki) may refer to the branding of slaves; some take it as the conjunction "for."

Chapter 4

1 And seven women shall take hold of one man in that day, saying,
"We will eat our own bread and wear our own clothing;
only let us be called by your name;
take away our reproach."
2 In that day the sprout of Yahweh shall be for beauty and for glory,
and the fruit of the land for pride and for splendor to the escaped of Israel.[a]

3 And it shall come to pass that he who is left in Zion and he who
remains in Jerusalem shall be called holy, every one who is written
for life in Jerusalem,
4 when the Lord shall have washed away the filth of the daughters
of Zion, and shall have purged the bloodstains of Jerusalem from its
midst by the spirit of judgment and by the spirit of burning.[b]
5 And Yahweh will create over the whole site of Mount Zion and over
her assemblies a cloud and smoke by day, and the shining of a flaming
fire by night; for over all the glory there shall be a canopy.[c]
6 And there shall be a booth for a shade in the daytime from the heat,
and for a refuge and a shelter from storm and from rain.

Notes

- a (4:2) Or "the sprout of Yahweh"; compare 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5; Zechariah 3:8. The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "and Judah" after "Israel."
- b (4:4) Or "of destruction." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "of storm" (saʿar for baʿer).
- c (4:5) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the words from "and smoke" in verse 5 through "a shade in the daytime" in verse 6, probably by a copyist's eye skipping from one similar word to another.

Chapter 5

1 Now I will sing to my well-beloved
a song of my beloved about his vineyard:
My well-beloved had a vineyard
on a very fruitful hill.[a]
2 He dug it up and gathered out its stones,
and planted it with the finest vine,
and built a tower in the midst of it,
and also hewed out a winepress in it;
and he looked for it to yield grapes,
and it yielded wild grapes.[b]
3 "And now, O inhabitants of Jerusalem and men of Judah,
judge, I pray you, between me and my vineyard.
4 What more was there to do for my vineyard,
that I have not done in it?
Why, when I looked for it to yield grapes,
did it yield wild grapes?

5 Now let me tell you
what I am going to do to my vineyard:
I will remove its hedge, and it will be eaten up;
I will tear down its wall, and it will be trampled.
6 I will turn it into a ruin;
no one will prune or hoe it,
but briers and thorns will take over;
I will also command the clouds
not to send rain on it."
7 For the vineyard of Yahweh of Armies is the house of Israel,
and the men of Judah his pleasant planting;
and he looked for justice, but behold, bloodshed;
for righteousness, but behold, a cry![c]
8 Woe to those who join house to house,
who add field to field,
until there is no room,
and you are made to dwell alone in the midst of the land!
9 In my ears Yahweh of Armies has sworn:
"Surely many houses shall be desolate,
great and fair, without inhabitant.[d]
10 For ten acres of vineyard shall yield about six gallons,
and six bushels of seed shall yield about half a bushel."[e]
11 Woe to those who rise up early in the morning,
that they may follow strong drink;
who tarry late into the night,
till wine inflames them!
12 And the lyre and the harp, the tambourine and the flute, and wine are at their feasts;
but they do not regard the work of Yahweh,
nor see the deeds of his hands.
13 Therefore my people go into exile for lack of knowledge;
and their honored men are famished,
and their multitude is parched with thirst.
14 Therefore Sheol has enlarged her appetite,
and opened her mouth without measure;

and their glory and their multitude and their tumult go down into it,
and he who exults among them.[f]
15 And man is bowed down, and each one is brought low,
and the eyes of the lofty are brought low.
16 But Yahweh of Armies is exalted in justice,
and God the Holy One shows himself holy in righteousness.
17 Then the lambs shall graze as in their pasture,
and strangers shall eat among the ruins of the fat ones.[g]
18 Woe to those who draw iniquity with cords of falsehood,
and sin as with cart ropes;
19 who say, "Let him make speed, let him hasten his work,
that we may see it;
and let the counsel of the Holy One of Israel draw near and come,
that we may know it!"
20 Woe to those who call evil good, and good evil;
who put darkness for light, and light for darkness;
who put bitter for sweet, and sweet for bitter!
21 Woe to those who are wise in their own eyes,
and prudent in their own sight!
22 Woe to those who are mighty at drinking wine,
and valiant men at mixing strong drink;
23 who justify the wicked for a bribe,
and take away the righteousness of the righteous from him!
24 Therefore, as flames lick up stubble
and dry grass shrivels in the fire,
so their roots will decay,
and their blossoms will drift off like dust.
They have rejected the teaching of Yahweh of Armies
and despised the word of Israel's Holy One.[h]
25 Therefore the anger of Yahweh is kindled against his people,
and he has stretched out his hand against them and struck them;
and the mountains trembled,
and their dead bodies became like refuse in the streets.

For all this his anger has not turned back,
but his hand is stretched out still.[i]
26 And he will lift up a banner to the nations from far away,
and will whistle for them from the end of the earth;
and behold, they shall come with speed, swiftly.
27 None shall be weary nor stumble among them;
none shall slumber nor sleep;
neither shall the girdle of their loins be loosed,
nor the thong of their sandals be broken;
28 whose arrows are sharp,
and all their bows bent;
their horses' hoofs are counted like flint,
and their wheels like a whirlwind.
29 Their roaring shall be like a lioness,
they shall roar like young lions;
they shall growl and lay hold of the prey,
and carry it off, and none shall deliver.
30 And they shall growl over it in that day
like the roaring of the sea;
and if one gazes at the land,
behold, darkness, distress;
even the light grows dark in its clouds.

Notes

- a (5:1) Or "the song of my beloved." Hebrew "on a horn, a son of oil," that is, a fertile hillside.
- b (5:2) Hebrew be'ushim, "stinking things," that is, rotten or worthless grapes.
- c (5:7) A wordplay: "justice" (mishpat) but "bloodshed" (mispah); "righteousness" (tsedaqah) but "a cry" (tse'aqah), the outcry of the oppressed.
- d (5:9) Hebrew "In my ears, Yahweh of Armies"; "has sworn" is supplied (compare 22:14). The Septuagint reads "these things have reached the ears of the Lord of hosts."
- e (5:10) Hebrew "ten yokes of vineyard," the land ten teams of oxen could plow in a day, "shall yield one bath, and a homer of seed shall yield an ephah." A bath was about 6 gallons (22 liters); a homer about 6 bushels (220 liters); an ephah about 3/5 bushel (22 liters), a tenth of the seed sown.
- f (5:14) Sheol, the realm of the dead; the Septuagint reads Hades.

- g (5:17) "The fat ones," that is, the rich. For gerim, "strangers," some read gedayim, "kids." The Septuagint reads "lambs shall feed on the waste places of them that are taken away."
- h (5:24) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and flaming fire" for "and dry grass in the flame."
- i (5:25) This refrain recurs at 9:12, 17, 21; 10:4.

Chapter 6

1 In the year that King Uzziah died I saw the Lord sitting upon a
throne, high and lifted up, and his train filled the temple.[a]
2 Above him stood the seraphim. Each one had six wings: with two
he covered his face, and with two he covered his feet, and with two
he flew.[b]
3 And one called to another and said:
"Holy, holy, holy is Yahweh of Armies;
the whole earth is full of his glory!"[c]
4 And the foundations of the thresholds shook at the voice of him who
called, and the house was filled with smoke.
5 Then I said, "Woe is me, for I am undone! For I am a man unclean of
lips, and in the midst of a people unclean of lips I dwell; and the King,
Yahweh of Armies, my eyes have seen!"[d] 6 Then one of the seraphim
flew to me. In his hand was a glowing coal that he had taken from
the altar with tongs. 7 And he touched my mouth with it and said,
"Behold, this has touched your lips; and your iniquity is taken away,
and your sin is atoned for."
8 Then I heard the Lord's voice say, "Whom shall I send? And who
will go for us?" And I said, "Here I am! Send me."
9 And he said, "Go, and say to this people:
'Hear indeed, but do not understand;
and see indeed, but do not perceive.'
10 Make fat the heart of this people,
make heavy their ears,
and smear over their eyes;
so that they may not see with their eyes,
nor hear with their ears,

nor their heart understand,
and they turn and be healed."[e]
11 Then I said, "Lord, how long?" And he answered:
"Until cities lie waste without inhabitant,
and houses without man,
and the land is utterly desolate,
12 and Yahweh has removed men far away,
and the forsaken places are many in the midst of the land.
13 If a tenth is still left in it,
that too will be burned,
like a terebinth or an oak
that leaves a stump after it is felled.
The holy seed is the stump."[f]

Notes

- a (6:1) About 740 BC. "The Lord," Hebrew 'Adonai. "Train," the skirts of his robe. Compare John 12:41.
- b (6:2) Seraphim, "burning ones," heavenly beings; the word is also used of serpents (14:29; 30:6; Numbers 21:6). "Feet" may be a modest term for the lower body.
- c (6:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Holy, holy" (twice). Compare Revelation 4:8.
- d (6:5) Or "I am silenced" or "I am ruined."
- e (6:10) Verses 9–10 are quoted in Matthew 13:14–15; Mark 4:12; John 12:40; Acts 28:26–27, largely following the Septuagint, which reads "For the heart of this people has become fat." In verse 10 the Great Isaiah Scroll reads hashem for hashmen ("make fat"), perhaps a shortened spelling, or "appall," as some have proposed.
- f (6:13) Or "at its felling." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads mushleket, "cast down," for beshalleket, "at its felling," and bamah for bam ("in them"); the sense is uncertain. The Septuagint lacks the last line.

Chapter 7

1 And it came to pass in the days of Ahaz the son of Jotham, the son of Uzziah, king of Judah, that Rezin the king of Syria and Pekah the son of Remaliah, king of Israel, went up to Jerusalem to make war against it, but could not prevail against it.[a] 2 And it was told the house of David, saying, "Syria has settled upon Ephraim." And his heart and the heart of his people shook as the trees of the forest shake before the wind.[b]

3 Then Yahweh said to Isaiah, "Go out now to meet Ahaz, you and
Shear-jashub your son, at the end of the conduit of the upper pool,
on the highway to the washers' field;[c]
4 and say to him, 'Be careful and keep still; have no fear, neither
let your heart be faint because of these two stubs of smoldering
firebrands, at the hot anger of Rezin and Syria and Remaliah's son.
5 Aram has hatched an evil plan against you—and so have Ephraim
and Remaliah's son—saying,
6 "Let's invade Judah, terrify it, split it open for ourselves, and make
the son of Tabeel king over it,"[d]
7 thus says the Lord Yahweh:
"It shall not stand,
neither shall it come to pass.[e]
8 For the head of Syria is Damascus,
and the head of Damascus is Rezin.
And within sixty-five years
Ephraim shall be shattered from being a people.[f]
9 And Samaria is the head of Ephraim,
and Remaliah's son is the head of Samaria.
If you will not hold firm in trust,
surely you will not be held firm."'"[g]
10 And Yahweh spoke again to Ahaz, saying,
11 "Ask a sign of Yahweh your God; ask it either in the depth below or
in the height above."[h]
12 But Ahaz said, "I will not ask, neither will I put Yahweh to the test."
13 And he said, "Listen, house of David! Is it too little for you to tire
men out, that you will tire out my God as well?
14 Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign:
Behold, the young woman shall conceive and bear a son,
and shall call his name Immanuel.[i]
15 Butter and honey shall he eat,
when he knows to refuse the evil and choose the good.[j]
16 For before the child knows to refuse the evil and choose the good,
the land whose two kings you dread shall be forsaken.

17 Yahweh will bring on you and on your people and on the house of your father such days

as have not come from the day when Ephraim broke away from Judah—the king of Assyria."[k]

18 On that day Yahweh will whistle for the flies at the far ends of Egypt's rivers, and for the bees in the land of Assyria. 19 And they shall come and shall rest, all of them, in the steep ravines, and in the clefts of the rocks, and upon all thornbushes, and upon all watering places.[l] 20 In that day the Lord will shave with a razor that is hired beyond the River—with the king of Assyria—the head and the hair of the feet; and it shall also sweep away the beard.[m] 21 And it shall come to pass in that day that a man shall keep alive a young cow and two sheep; 22 and it shall come to pass, for the abundance of milk that they give, he shall eat butter; for butter and honey shall every one eat who is left in the midst of the land. 23 And it shall come to pass in that day that every place where there were a thousand vines, worth about twenty-five pounds of silver, shall become briers and thorns.[n] 24 With arrows and with bow shall one come there, because all the land shall become briers and thorns. 25 And as for all the hills that were dug with the hoe, you shall not come there for fear of briers and thorns; but it shall be a place for sending out oxen and for the treading of sheep.

Notes

- a (7:1) Ahaz reigned about 735–715 BC. Rezin, perhaps "delight," the last king of Aram (Syria) at Damascus; Pekah, "opened (eyes)"; Remaliah, perhaps "Yahweh has adorned." This is the Syro-Ephraimite war of about 734 BC; compare 2 Kings 16:5.
- b (7:2) Hebrew Aram, the Aramean kingdom of Damascus. Ephraim, "doubly fruitful," here the northern kingdom of Israel. "Settled upon," or "is allied with." David, "beloved."
- c (7:3) Shear-jashub, "a remnant shall return" (compare 10:21–22). Or "the fuller's field." Compare 36:2.
- d (7:6) Tabeel, "God is good," here with a pun on "good for nothing" (tav'al); perhaps an Aramean candidate for the throne.
- e (7:7) Hebrew 'Adonai YHWH.
- f (7:8) Damascus, the capital of Aram. Samaria (verse 9), the capital of the northern kingdom, fell to Assyria in 722 BC; the sixty-five years may reckon to the resettlement of the land (compare 2 Kings 17:24; Ezra 4:2).

- g (7:9) A wordplay: "If you will not be firm (ta'aminu), you shall not be made firm (te'amenu)."
- h (7:11) Or "make it deep as Sheol," reading she'alah as she'olah.
- i (7:14) Hebrew ha'almah, "the young woman," a girl of marriageable age, unmarried or newly married; it is not the usual Hebrew word for a virgin (betulah), and it does not of itself say whether she is a virgin. Or "is with child and is about to bear a son." The Septuagint, made about two centuries before Christ, renders the word parthenos, ordinarily "virgin," and Matthew 1:23 quotes the Septuagint ("Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall call his name Immanuel") of the birth of Jesus. The second-century Jewish Greek translations of Aquila, Symmachus, and Theodotion are reported by early Christian writers to have read neanis, "young woman." Immanuel, 'immanu 'el, "God is with us" (compare 8:8, 10). "Shall call," or "you shall call"; the Septuagint reads "you shall call," and the Great Isaiah Scroll "he shall call" (or "one shall call"). The Great Isaiah Scroll also reads Yahweh for 'Adonai ("the Lord").
- j (7:15) Or "curds and honey," the food of a land returned to pasture (verse 22). "When he knows," or "so that he may know."
- k (7:17) Assyria, the great power of upper Mesopotamia, with its capital at Nineveh.
- l (7:19) Or "all the pastures."
- m (7:20) The River, the Euphrates. "The hair of the feet," the body hair; shaving was a mark of humiliation (2 Samuel 10:4).
- n (7:23) Hebrew "a thousand of silver," that is, a thousand shekels, about 25 pounds (11.5 kilograms).

Chapter 8

1 Yahweh said to me, "Take a large tablet and write on it in ordinary
letters, 'Belonging to Maher-shalal-hash-baz.'[a] 2 And I will take for
myself faithful witnesses to testify, Uriah the priest and Zechariah the
son of Jeberechiah."[b] 3 And I went to the prophetess, and she conceived
and bore a son. Then Yahweh said to me, "Call his name Maher-
shalal-hash-baz;[c] 4 for before the child knows how to cry 'My father'
and 'My mother,' the riches of Damascus and the spoil of Samaria
shall be carried away before the king of Assyria."
5 And Yahweh spoke to me yet again, saying,
6 "Because this people has refused
the waters of Shiloah that go softly,
and rejoices in Rezin and the son of Remaliah;[d]
7 now therefore, behold, the Lord brings up upon them
the waters of the River, strong and many,

the king of Assyria and all his glory;
and it shall come up over all its channels,
and go over all its banks;
8 and it shall sweep on into Judah;
it shall overflow and pass through;
it shall reach even to the neck;
and the spreading of its wings shall fill the breadth of your land,
O Immanuel."[e]
9 Be broken, O peoples, and be shattered;
give ear, all you of far countries;
gird yourselves, and be shattered;
gird yourselves, and be shattered.[f]
10 Take counsel together, and it shall come to nothing;
speak the word, and it shall not stand;
for God is with us.[g]
11 For thus Yahweh spoke to me with a strong hand, and warned me not to walk in the way of this people, saying,[h]
12 "Do not call conspiracy
all that this people calls conspiracy;
neither fear what they fear,
nor be in dread.[i]
13 Yahweh of Armies, him shall you regard as holy;
he is the one for you to fear,
he is the one for you to dread.
14 And he shall become a holy place;
but a stone to strike against and a rock to trip over
for the two houses of Israel,
a trap and a snare
to the inhabitants of Jerusalem.[j]
15 And many shall stumble on it,
and fall and be broken,
and be snared and be taken."
16 Bind up the testimony;
seal the law among my disciples.[k]

17 And I will wait for Yahweh,
who hides his face from the house of Jacob,
and I will look for him.
18 Behold, I and the children whom Yahweh has given me are for signs
and for wonders in Israel from Yahweh of Armies, who dwells on
Mount Zion.[l]
19 And when they say to you, "Seek the mediums and the spiritists who
chirp and mutter," is it not to its God that a people should inquire?
On behalf of the living, should they inquire of the dead?[m] 20 To the
law and to the testimony! Surely those who do not speak according
to this word have no dawn.[n] 21 And they shall pass through it, hard
pressed and hungry; and it shall come to pass that when they are
hungry they shall fret themselves, and curse their king and their God,
and turn their faces upward; 22 and they shall look to the earth, and
behold, distress and darkness, the gloom of anguish; and into thick
darkness they shall be thrust.[o]

Notes

- a (8:1) Hebrew "with the stylus of a man," that is, in ordinary script. Maher-shalal-hash-baz, "the spoil speeds, the prey hastens," foretelling the plundering of Damascus and Samaria (verse 4).
- b (8:2) Uriah, "Yahweh is my light," the priest of 2 Kings 16:10–16; Zechariah, "Yahweh remembers"; Jeberechiah, "Yahweh blesses." "I will take," so the Hebrew; the Great Isaiah Scroll and the Septuagint read imperatives ("take for me" / "make … witnesses").
- c (8:3) The prophetess, probably Isaiah's wife.
- d (8:6) Shiloah, "sent," the gentle stream from the Gihon spring (compare Siloam, John 9:7), a symbol of the quiet rule of the house of David. "Rejoices in," the sense of the Hebrew is uncertain.
- e (8:8) Immanuel, "God is with us"; see 7:14.
- f (8:9) The Septuagint reads "Know, O nations"; some read "Be joined together" for "Be broken." The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the last line.
- g (8:10) Hebrew ʻimmanu ʼel, "God is with us," the name of 7:14.
- h (8:11) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and he turned me aside from walking" for "and warned me."
- i (8:12) Or "what they reverence." Compare 1 Peter 3:14–15.
- j (8:14) Compare Romans 9:33; 1 Peter 2:8.
- k (8:16) Or "instruction" (torah), here Isaiah's teaching.
- l (8:18) Compare Hebrews 2:13.

- m (8:19) Hebrew ’ovot and yidd‘onim, those who consulted ghosts and the spirits of the dead; compare Leviticus 19:31; 1 Samuel 28.
- n (8:20) Or “surely they shall speak according to this word, for which there is no dawn.” The Hebrew is difficult.
- o (8:22) In the Hebrew text 8:23 begins with the first line of English 9:1.

Chapter 9

1 Yet the gloom will lift from the land that was in anguish. At first
he brought shame on the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali,
but afterward he has made glorious the road by the sea, beyond the
Jordan, Galilee of the nations.[a]
2 People who walked in the dark have seen a great light.
For the inhabitants of a land of gloomy shadow,
light has begun to shine.[b]
3 You have made the nation larger
and increased its happiness;
they celebrate in your presence as people do at harvest,
as they shout with joy when dividing plunder.[c]
4 For the yoke of his burden,
and the bar across his shoulder,
the rod of his taskmaster,
you have broken as on the day of Midian.[d]
5 For every boot of the warrior that tramped in the tumult,
and every cloak rolled in blood,
shall be for burning, food for the fire.
6 A child is born to us, and a son is given to us;
authority is on his shoulder,
and his name will be
Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God,
Eternal Father, Prince of Peace.[e]
7 Of the increase of his rule and of peace
there shall be no end,
upon the throne of David and over his kingdom,
to establish it and to uphold it
with justice and with righteousness

from now on and forever.
The zeal of Yahweh of Armies will do this.[f]
8 A word the Lord sent into Jacob,
and it has fallen upon Israel;[g]
9 and all the people shall know it,
Ephraim and the inhabitant of Samaria,
who say in pride and in arrogance of heart:
10 "Bricks have fallen down,
but with hewn stone we will build;
sycamores are felled,
but cedars we will set in their stead."[h]
11 So Yahweh raises the foes of Rezin against him,
and spurs on his enemies,
12 Syria in front and the Philistines behind;
and they eat up Israel with gaping mouth.
For all this his anger has not turned back,
and his hand is stretched out still.[i]
13 Yet the people have not turned to him who struck them,
nor have they sought Yahweh of Armies.
14 So Yahweh cuts off from Israel head and tail,
palm branch and reed, in one day—
15 the elder and the man of rank, he is the head;
and the prophet who teaches lies, he is the tail.
16 For those who lead this people lead them astray,
and those who are led by them are swallowed up.[j]
17 So the Lord takes no pleasure in their young men
and shows no pity to their orphans and widows,
for all of them are ungodly and do evil,
and every mouth utters nonsense.
Despite all this, his anger has not turned away,
and his hand is still raised.[k]
18 Wickedness blazes like a fire that devours thorns and briers;
it ignites the dense forest,
and the smoke swirls upward in a column.

19 Through the wrath of Yahweh of Armies the land is scorched,
and the people are like food for the fire;
no man spares his brother.[l]
20 They slice meat on the right, and are still hungry;
they eat on the left, and are not satisfied;
each devours the flesh of his own arm,[m]
21 Manasseh devours Ephraim, and Ephraim devours Manasseh,
and together they turn on Judah.
Despite all this, his anger has not turned away,
and his hand is still raised.[n]

Notes

- a (9:1) This verse is 8:23 in the Hebrew, and English 9:2–21 are Hebrew 9:1–20. Zebulun, "honor" or "dwelling"; Naphtali, "my wrestling"; Galilee, "circle" or "district," here the region of the nations around Israel's north. Or "Galilee of the Gentiles." Verses 1–2 are quoted in Matthew 4:15–16 of the ministry of Jesus in Galilee.
- b (9:2) Or "deep darkness."
- c (9:3) The Hebrew written text (ketiv) reads "you have not made great its joy"; the text as traditionally read aloud (qere) has "to it" (lo) for "not" (lo'), as here. The Great Isaiah Scroll has the written form, "not."
- d (9:4) Midian, "strife"; the day of Gideon's victory over Midian (Judges 7). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Madim."
- e (9:6) Hebrew pele' yo'ets, 'el gibbor, 'avi'ad, sar shalom; or "a Wonder of a Counselor," "God the Warrior" (compare 10:21, where 'el gibbor is God himself), "Father forever." Some, following medieval Jewish interpretation, take the long name as a sentence describing God who gives the child ("the Wonderful Counselor, the Mighty God, the Everlasting Father, calls him Prince of Peace"). The Septuagint reads "and his name is called the Messenger of great counsel, for I will bring peace upon the princes." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Prince of the peace" and "and he called." In the Hebrew this is 9:5.
- f (9:7) In the traditional Hebrew text the first word (lemarbeh, "of the increase") is written with a final form of the letter mem in the middle of the word, a feature long discussed by interpreters; the Great Isaiah Scroll writes it normally. David, "beloved."
- g (9:8) The Septuagint reads "The Lord has sent death" (dever, "pestilence," for davar, "word").
- h (9:10) Or "sycamore figs," a common, cheap timber.
- i (9:12) Hebrew Aram from the front and the Philistines from behind, that is, east and west. The Septuagint reads "Syria from the rising of the sun, and the Greeks from the setting of the sun." Compare 5:25.

- j (9:16) Or “confused.”
- k (9:17) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “does not spare” (yahmol for yismah).
- l (9:19) Or “is shaken” or “burned up”; the Hebrew neʿtam is uncertain.
- m (9:20) Or, with some, “the flesh of his neighbor” (reʿo for zeroʿo). Manasseh, “causing to forget”; Ephraim, “doubly fruitful,” the two great tribes of the northern kingdom.
- n (9:21) See 5:25.

Chapter 10

1 Woe to those who decree unjust decrees,
and the writers who keep writing oppression,
2 to turn aside the needy from justice,
and to rob the poor of my people of their right,
so that widows become their spoil,
and they plunder the fatherless!
3 What will you do on the day of punishment,
and in the ruin that comes from afar?
To whom will you flee for help,
and where will you leave your wealth?[a]
4 Nothing remains but to crouch among the prisoners,
or to fall among the slain.
For all this his anger has not turned back,
and his hand is stretched out still.[b]
5 Woe to Assyria, the rod of my anger!
The staff in their hand is my fury.[c]
6 I send him against an ungodly nation,
I order him against a people who anger me,
to seize loot and take plunder
and to stomp on them like mud in the streets.
7 But this is not what he means,
nor is it what his heart devises;
but to destroy is in his heart,
and to cut off many nations.
8 For he says:
“Are my princes not every one of them kings?

9 Is Calno not as Carchemish?
Is Hamath not as Arpad?
Is Samaria not as Damascus?[d]
10 As my hand has reached the kingdoms of the idols,
whose carved images were more than those of Jerusalem and of Samaria,
11 shall I not do to Jerusalem and her images
as I have done to Samaria and her idols?"
12 But when the Lord completes everything he is doing against Mount Zion and Jerusalem, I will punish the king of Assyria for the fruit of his proud heart and for his arrogant, haughty eyes.[e]
13 For he says:
"By the strength of my hand I have done it,
and by my wisdom, for I have understanding;
I have removed the borders of peoples,
and plundered their treasures;
and like a mighty one I have brought down those who sat on thrones.[f]
14 My hand has found the riches of the peoples
as one finds a nest;
and as men gather abandoned eggs,
so I have gathered all the earth;
and there was none that moved a wing,
or opened a mouth, or chirped."
15 Does the axe brag against the one who chops with it?
Does the saw boast over the one who saws with it?
It would be like a rod swinging the person who lifts it,
or a staff raising someone who is not made of wood![g]
16 Therefore the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
will send wasting sickness among his fat ones;
and under his glory a burning shall be kindled,
like the burning of fire.[h]
17 And the Light of Israel shall become a fire,
and his Holy One a flame;

and it shall burn and devour
his thorns and his briers in one day.
18 And the glory of his forest and of his fruitful field
he will consume, both soul and body;
and it shall be as when a sick man wastes away.[i]
19 And the rest of the trees of his forest shall be few,
so that a child could write them down.
20 And it shall come to pass in that day that the remnant of Israel, and the survivors of the house of Jacob, shall no more lean upon him who struck them, but shall lean upon Yahweh, the Holy One of Israel, in truth.
21 A remnant shall return, the remnant of Jacob,
to the Mighty God.[j]
22 For though your people Israel be as the sand of the sea,
only a remnant of them shall return.
Destruction is decreed,
overflowing with righteousness.[k]
23 For the Lord, Yahweh of Armies, will bring about destruction, just as determined,
throughout the whole land.[l]
24 Therefore this is what the Lord, Yahweh of Armies, says: "My people who live in Zion, do not fear Assyria, though he hits you with a rod and raises his staff against you, as Egypt did.[m] 25 For in a very little while the indignation will come to an end, and my anger will turn to their destruction. 26 Yahweh of Armies will lash him with a whip, like the slaughter of Midian at the rock of Oreb; he will lift his staff over the sea as he did in Egypt.[n] 27 And it shall come to pass in that day that his burden shall depart from your shoulder, and his yoke from your neck; and the yoke shall be broken because of fatness."[o]
28 He has come to Aiath;
he has passed through Migron;
at Michmash he stores his baggage.[p]
29 They have gone across the ravine;
"Geba shall be our lodging," they say;

Ramah is afraid;
Saul's Gibeah is fleeing.[q]
30 Cry aloud with your voice, O daughter of Gallim!
Listen, O Laishah!
Answer her, O poor Anathoth![r]
31 Madmenah is in flight;
the inhabitants of Gebim flee for refuge.[s]
32 Yet today he will stand at Nob;
he waves his hand against the mountain of the daughter of Zion,
the hill of Jerusalem.[t]
33 Behold, the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
will lop the boughs with terrifying power;
and the tall of stature shall be hewn down,
and the lofty shall be brought low.
34 And he will cut down the thickets of the forest with iron,
and Lebanon shall fall by a Mighty One.[u]

Notes

- a (10:3) Hebrew "your glory."
- b (10:4) Or "Without me they shall crouch." The Hebrew is uncertain. See 5:25.
- c (10:5) Or "Ah, Assyria." Assyria's king is the tool of God's judgment (verses 5–19).
- d (10:9) Calno (Calneh), Carchemish (on the Euphrates), Hamath, and Arpad were cities of Syria and northern Mesopotamia taken by Assyria about 740–717 BC.
- e (10:12) The Lord, here 'Adonai.
- f (10:13) Or "like a bull." "Treasures," or "stores"; the Great Isaiah Scroll lacks this word.
- g (10:15) Or "as if a rod should wave him who lifts it."
- h (10:16) Hebrew ha'adon, "the Lord."
- i (10:18) Or "as when a standard-bearer faints"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- j (10:21) Hebrew she'ar yashuv, the name of Isaiah's son (7:3). Hebrew 'el gibbor, as in 9:6.
- k (10:22) Verses 22–23 are quoted in Romans 9:27–28 from the Septuagint ("a remnant of them shall be saved").
- l (10:23) Or "in the midst of all the earth."
- m (10:24) Egypt, Hebrew Mitsrayim, the land of Israel's first bondage.
- n (10:26) Oreb, "raven," the Midianite prince killed at the rock that bore his name (Judges 7:25).

- o (10:27) Hebrew “from before oil” or “from before fatness,” perhaps meaning the ox has grown too fat for its yoke; many emend to “he has gone up from Samaria” or “from Rimmon.” The verse division is uncertain; the last words may begin verse 28.
- p (10:28) Verses 28–32 trace an army’s advance on Jerusalem from the north. Aiath, probably Ai, “ruin”; Migron, perhaps “precipice”; Michmash, “hidden place.”
- q (10:29) Geba and Gibeah, both “hill”; Ramah, “height.” Saul, “asked for,” Israel’s first king.
- r (10:30) Gallim, “heaps”; Laishah, “lion”; Anathoth, the priestly town of Jeremiah. “Answer her,” reading ‘aniha; Hebrew ‘aniyyah, “poor.”
- s (10:31) Madmenah, “dung heap”; Gebim, “cisterns” or “trenches.”
- t (10:32) Nob, the priests’ town (1 Samuel 21–22), within sight of Jerusalem. Hebrew ketiv “the house of the daughter of Zion”; the Great Isaiah Scroll lacks “house.”
- u (10:34) Or “by the Mighty One,” or “by a majestic one” (’addir). Lebanon here stands for the Assyrian army, as the forest image continues.

Chapter 11

1 And a shoot shall come out from the stock of Jesse,
and a branch out of his roots shall be fruitful.[a]
2 And the Spirit of Yahweh shall rest upon him,
the Spirit of wisdom and understanding,
the Spirit of counsel and might,
the Spirit of knowledge and of the fear of Yahweh.[b]
3 His delight will be the fear of Yahweh.
He will not give a verdict based on what his eyes see
or settle a case by what his ears hear;
4 but he will judge the poor with righteousness
and give fair rulings for the humble in the land;
he will hit the earth with the rod of his mouth,
and kill the wicked with the breath from his lips.[c]
5 And righteousness shall be the sash about his waist,
and faithfulness the sash about his hips.
6 And the wolf shall dwell with the lamb,
and the leopard shall lie down with the young goat,
and the calf and the young lion and the fatling together;
and a little child shall lead them.[d]

7 Cows and bears will feed together,
their young will rest side by side,
and lions will eat straw like oxen.
8 And the suckling child shall play by the cobra's hole,
and on the viper's nest the weaned child shall lay his hand.
9 They shall not hurt nor destroy
in all my holy mountain;
for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of Yahweh,
as the waters cover the sea.
10 And it shall come to pass in that day that the root of Jesse, who stands for a banner of the peoples—to him the nations shall seek, and his place of rest shall be glorious.[e]
11 And it shall come to pass in that day that the Lord will set his hand a second time to recover the remnant of his people that remains, from Assyria and from Egypt, from Pathros and from Cush, from Elam and from Shinar, from Hamath and from the coastlands of the sea.[f]
12 And he will raise a banner for the nations,
and will gather the outcasts of Israel,
and assemble the scattered of Judah
from the four corners of the earth.
13 And the jealousy of Ephraim shall depart,
and the adversaries of Judah shall be cut off;
Ephraim shall not envy Judah,
and Judah shall not harass Ephraim.
14 But they shall swoop down upon the shoulder of the Philistines on the west;
together they shall despoil the sons of the east;
Edom and Moab shall be the reach of their hand,
and the children of Ammon shall obey them.[g]
15 Yahweh will completely dry up the gulf of the Egyptian sea;
he will wave his hand over the River with his scorching wind
and split it into seven streams,
so that people can walk across in sandals.[h]
16 And there shall be a highway for the remnant of his people
that remains from Assyria,

as there was for Israel
on the day when they came up from the land of Egypt.

Notes

- a (11:1) Jesse, David's father (1 Samuel 16); the name's meaning is uncertain, perhaps "Yahweh exists" or "gift." "Branch," Hebrew netser; compare Matthew 2:23. The Septuagint reads "a rod … and a blossom shall come up from his root."
- b (11:2) The Septuagint adds "godliness" after "knowledge" and puts "the fear of God" in verse 3, giving the seven gifts of later Christian tradition.
- c (11:4) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and by the breath of his lips the wicked shall be put to death." Compare 2 Thessalonians 2:8.
- d (11:6) The Great Isaiah Scroll and the Septuagint read "shall graze" for "and the fatling"; compare 65:25.
- e (11:10) Quoted in Romans 15:12 from the Septuagint ("he who rises to rule the nations; in him shall the nations hope").
- f (11:11) Pathros, Upper (southern) Egypt; Cush, the Nile lands south of Egypt (Nubia); Elam, southwest Iran; Shinar, Babylonia; Hamath, in Syria. The Lord, here 'Adonai.
- g (11:14) Edom, "red," south and east of the Dead Sea; Moab, east of the Dead Sea; Ammon, east of the Jordan, around modern Amman.
- h (11:15) Or "will dry up" (some read hehrib for heherim). The River, the Euphrates. "Scorching," the Hebrew word is uncertain.

Chapter 12

1 And you shall say in that day:
"I will give thanks to you, Yahweh,
for though you were angry with me,
your anger turned away,
and you comfort me.[a]
2 Behold, God is my salvation;
I will trust, and will not be afraid;
for Yah, Yahweh, is my strength and my song,
and he has become my salvation."[b]
3 And with joy you shall draw water
from the springs of salvation.
4 And you shall say in that day:
"Give thanks to Yahweh, call on his name;
declare among the peoples what he has done;
make mention that his name is lifted high.

5 Sing to Yahweh, for he has done excellent things;
let it be known through all the earth.[c]
6 Cry out and shout, you who dwell in Zion,
for the Holy One of Israel is great among you."[d]

Notes

- a (12:1) "You" is singular here; in verse 4 it is plural. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and turned away."
- b (12:2) Yah, a short form of the divine name; compare Exodus 15:2; Psalm 118:14. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "God, God ('el 'el) is my salvation."
- c (12:5) Following the qere (muda'at); the ketiv has another passive form of the same verb. The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the word rendered "let it be known."
- d (12:6) Or "O inhabitress of Zion," a feminine form for the city's people.

Chapter 13

1 The oracle concerning Babylon, which Isaiah the son of Amoz saw.[a]
2 Raise a signal flag on a bare hilltop;
call out to them;
wave your hand so they will go through the gates of the nobles.
3 I myself have commanded my consecrated ones;
yes, I have called my mighty men for my anger,
my proudly exulting ones.[b]
4 The noise of a multitude on the mountains,
like that of a great people!
The noise of the uproar of kingdoms,
of nations gathered together!
Yahweh of Armies is mustering
an army for battle.
5 They come from a far country,
from the end of the heavens,
Yahweh and the weapons of his indignation,
to destroy the whole land.[c]
6 Wail, for the day of Yahweh is near!
As destruction from the Almighty it shall come.[d]
7 Therefore all hands shall go limp,
and every man's heart shall melt,

8 and they shall be terrified.
Pangs and pains shall seize them;
they shall writhe like a woman in labor;
they shall look aghast at one another;
their faces shall be faces of flame.
9 Behold, the day of Yahweh comes,
cruel, with fury and burning anger,
to make the land a desolation,
and to destroy its sinners from it.
10 For the stars of the heavens and their constellations
shall not give their light;
the sun shall be dark at its rising,
and the moon shall not shed its light.[e]
11 I will punish the world for its evil,
the wicked for their wrongdoing.
I will end the pride of the haughty
and humble the arrogance of the ruthless.
12 I will make a mortal scarcer than pure gold,
even a man than the fine gold of Ophir.[f]
13 Therefore I will make the heavens tremble,
and the earth shall be shaken out of its place,
at the wrath of Yahweh of Armies
in the day of his burning anger.
14 And like a hunted gazelle,
and like sheep that no one gathers,
they shall each turn to his own people,
and each flee to his own land.
15 Every one who is found shall be thrust through,
and every one who is caught shall fall by the sword.
16 Their infants also shall be dashed to pieces before their eyes;
their houses shall be plundered,
and their wives ravished.[g]
17 Behold, I will stir up the Medes against them,
who will not value silver,
and take no delight in gold.[h]

18 And their bows shall shatter the young men;
and they shall have no pity on the fruit of the womb;
their eye shall not spare children.
19 Babylon, the most glorious of kingdoms,
the splendor and boast of the Chaldeans,
will end up like Sodom and Gomorrah, which God overturned.[i]
20 It shall never be inhabited,
nor lived in from generation to generation;
no Arab shall pitch his tent there,
nor shall shepherds make their flocks lie down there.
21 But desert creatures shall lie down there,
and their houses shall be full of howling beasts;
and ostriches shall dwell there,
and wild goats shall dance there.[j]
22 And hyenas shall cry in its towers,
and jackals in the palaces of pleasure;
and its time is near to come,
and its days shall not be prolonged.[k]

Notes

- a (13:1) Hebrew massa', "burden," "utterance," a title for the oracles against the nations in chapters 13–23. Babylon (Hebrew Bavel), the great city on the Euphrates; Genesis 11:9 links the name with balal, "confuse."
- b (13:3) Or "those who exult in my majesty."
- c (13:5) Or "the whole earth."
- d (13:6) Hebrew Shaddai, traditionally "the Almighty," with a wordplay: "as shod (destruction) from Shadday."
- e (13:10) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "shall not shine" (a different verb). Compare Matthew 24:29; Mark 13:24–25.
- f (13:12) Ophir, a distant land famed for gold (1 Kings 9:28), perhaps in southern Arabia or East Africa.
- g (13:16) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the last line.
- h (13:17) The Medes, a people of northwest Iran, who joined with the Persians to take Babylon in 539 BC.
- i (13:19) The Chaldeans, the people of southern Babylonia whose dynasty ruled Babylon in the 7th–6th centuries BC. Sodom and Gomorrah, see 1:9.
- j (13:21) The identity of several of the animals in verses 21–22 is uncertain. "Wild goats," Hebrew se'irim, also "goat-demons" (compare Leviticus 17:7).
- k (13:22) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "again" ("shall not be prolonged again").

Chapter 14

1 For Yahweh will have mercy on Jacob, and will yet choose Israel, and
settle them in their own soil; and the sojourner shall join himself to
them, and they shall cleave to the house of Jacob.[a] 2 And peoples shall
take them and bring them to their place; and the house of Israel shall
possess them in the land of Yahweh as male and female servants; and
they shall take captive those who took them captive, and rule over
those who oppressed them.[b]
3 And it shall come to pass in the day that Yahweh gives you rest from
your pain and turmoil, and from the hard service with which you
were made to serve,
4 that you shall take up this taunt against the king of Babylon, and say:
"How the oppressor has ceased,
the insolent fury ceased![c]
5 Yahweh has broken the staff of the wicked,
the scepter of rulers,
6 that struck the peoples in wrath
with an unceasing stroke,
that ruled the nations in anger
with a persecution none restrained.
7 The whole earth is at rest and is quiet;
they break forth into singing.
8 Even the cypresses rejoice over you,
the cedars of Lebanon:
'Since you lay down,
no feller has come up against us.'
9 Sheol beneath is stirred up for you,
to meet you at your coming;
it rouses the shades for you,
all the leaders of the earth;
it makes rise from their thrones
all the kings of the nations.[d]
10 All of them shall answer
and say to you:

‘You too have become weak as we are!
You have become like us!’
11 Your splendor has been brought down to Sheol,
along with the music of your harps;
maggots are your bed beneath you,
and worms are your blanket.
12 How you are fallen from heaven,
O shining one, son of the dawn!
How you are cut down to the ground,
you who laid low the nations![e]
13 But you said in your heart,
‘Into heaven I will go up;
higher than the stars of God
I will raise my throne;
and I will sit on the mount of assembly
in the far reaches of the north;[f]
14 I will ascend above the heights of the clouds;
I will make myself like the Most High.’[g]
15 Yet you shall be brought down to Sheol,
to the far reaches of the pit.
16 They that see you shall gaze at you,
they shall consider you:
‘Is this the man who made the earth to quake,
that made kingdoms shake,
17 that made the world as a wilderness,
and tore down its cities,
that would not open the house of his prisoners?’
18 All the kings of the nations,
every one of them, rest in honor,
each in his own tomb;
19 but you are flung out of your tomb
as a detested shoot,
covered with the slain, run through with the sword,
who descend to the stones of the pit,
as a carcass trampled under foot.[h]

20 With them you shall have no share in burial,
for your land you have ruined,
your people you have killed.
The seed of evildoers
shall not be named forever.
21 Make ready a slaughter for his children
for the guilt of their fathers,
that they not rise up and take the earth,
nor fill the surface of the world with cities."[i]
22 "And I will rise up against them," says Yahweh of Armies, "and cut off from Babylon name and remnant, offspring and descendant," says Yahweh.[j] 23 "I will make it a home for hedgehogs and a place of marshes; I will sweep it with the broom of destruction," declares Yahweh of Armies.[k]
24 Yahweh of Armies has sworn, saying:
"Surely as I have planned,
so shall it be;
and as I have purposed,
so shall it stand:
25 to break Assyria in my land,
and on my mountains to trample him under foot;
and his yoke shall depart from them,
and his burden depart from their shoulder."[l]
26 This is the plan decided for the whole earth,
and this is the hand stretched out over all the nations.
27 For Yahweh of Armies has purposed,
and who shall annul it?
And his hand is stretched out,
and who shall turn it back?
28 In the year that King Ahaz died this oracle came:[m]
29 Do not celebrate, all you Philistines,
because the rod that beat you is broken;
for from the snake's root will come a viper,
and its offspring will be a flying fiery serpent.[n]

30 And the firstborn of the poor shall feed,
and the needy shall lie down in safety;
but I will kill your root with famine,
and your remnant shall be slain.[o]
31 Wail, gate! Cry out, city!
Panic, all you Philistines!
For a cloud of smoke is coming from the north,
and no one lags behind in his ranks.[p]
32 What then shall one answer the messengers of the nation?
"Yahweh has founded Zion,
and in her the afflicted of his people shall find refuge."

Notes

- a (14:1) Or "the stranger," the foreigner living among Israel.
- b (14:2) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "many" ("many peoples") and reads "to their land and to their place."
- c (14:4) Hebrew madhebah, a word otherwise unknown (traditionally "the golden city"). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads marhebah, "insolence" or "onslaught" (compare rahav, "arrogance," 3:5), a reading long proposed by scholars and supported by the ancient versions; the Septuagint reads "the taskmaster."
- d (14:9) Sheol, the realm of the dead. Hebrew repha'im, the dead, the "shades." Hebrew "the he-goats of the earth," that is, the leaders.
- e (14:12) Hebrew helel ben shahar, "shining one, son of dawn," probably the morning star (the planet Venus), here a taunt against the king of Babylon, using imagery known from Canaanite myth, in which a bright deity aspires to a higher throne and is cast down. The Septuagint renders heosphoros, "light-bringer," "the morning star," and the Latin Vulgate lucifer, "light-bearer," the Latin name of the morning star; from the Latin comes the name Lucifer, which later Christian interpretation applied to Satan (compare Luke 10:18; Revelation 12:7–9). The Great Isaiah Scroll writes the word with an extra letter (heylil) but has no difference of sense. Or "you who weakened the nations."
- f (14:13) Hebrew Tsaphon, "the north," also the name of a mountain (Mount Zaphon, Jebel Aqra in Syria) regarded in Canaanite religion as the home of the gods. Or "the mount of meeting."
- g (14:14) Hebrew 'Elyon, "the Most High."
- h (14:19) Or "like a rejected shoot"; some read "like a loathsome miscarriage" (nephel for netser).
- i (14:21) Or "with ruins" (some read 'iyyim for 'arim).
- j (14:22) Hebrew "name and remnant, offspring (nin) and descendant (neked)."
- k (14:23) Or "the owl" or "the bittern"; the animal is uncertain.

- l (14:25) Assyria, compare 10:5–19; 37:36–38.
- m (14:28) Ahaz died about 715 BC (some date it 727). Hebrew massa', "oracle"; see 13:1.
- n (14:29) Philistia, the land of the Philistines; compare 2:6. Hebrew saraph me'opheph, "a flying seraph," perhaps a winged serpent; compare 6:2; 30:6; Numbers 21:6.
- o (14:30) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and I will slay your remnant." Some read "the firstborn of the poor shall feed in my pastures" (bekhari for bekhore).
- p (14:31) Or "there is no one alone at his appointed place." The Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 15

1 The oracle concerning Moab.
Because in a night Ar of Moab is laid waste,
Moab is undone;
because in a night Kir of Moab is laid waste,
Moab is undone.[a]
2 People go up to the temple, and Dibon goes to its hilltop shrines, to weep;
Moab wails over Nebo and over Medeba;
every head is shaved bald,
and every beard is cut off.[b]
3 In their streets they gird themselves with sackcloth;
on their housetops and in their squares
every one wails, going down in weeping.
4 And Heshbon cries out, and Elealeh;
their voice is heard as far as Jahaz;
therefore the armed men of Moab cry aloud;
his soul trembles within him.[c]
5 My heart cries out for Moab;
her fugitives flee as far as Zoar and Eglath-shelishiyah;
the slope of Luhith is climbed in tears,
and along the road to Horonaim
they raise a cry of devastation.[d]
6 For the waters of Nimrim are desolate;
for the grass is withered, the new growth fails,
there is no green thing.[e]

7 So the wealth they have gotten,
and their stored-up goods,
they bear off across the Brook of the Willows.[f]
8 For the cry has gone around the border of Moab;
its wailing reaches to Eglaim,
and its wailing to Beer-elim.[g]
9 Dimon's waters are full of blood,
and I will bring even more on Dimon:
a lion for those who escape from Moab
and for those left in the land.[h]

Notes

- a (15:1) Moab, the kingdom east of the Dead Sea; Genesis 19:37 links the name with "from father." Ar and Kir, principal cities of Moab; Kir, "wall" or "city." "Undone," or "silenced."
- b (15:2) Or "to Bayith (the house)." Dibon, Nebo, and Medeba, towns of Moab; Nebo also a mountain and the name of a god. Shaving the head and beard were rites of mourning.
- c (15:4) Heshbon, Elealeh, and Jahaz, towns of northern Moab. The Septuagint reads "the loins of Moab cry out."
- d (15:5) Zoar, "small," at the south end of the Dead Sea (Genesis 19:22); Eglath-shelishiyah, perhaps "the third Eglath"; Luhith and Horonaim ("two caves") are mentioned also on the Moabite Stone. Or "her nobles."
- e (15:6) Nimrim, "leopards," a stream in southern Moab.
- f (15:7) Or "the Brook of the Poplars" (or "of the Arabah"), probably the Zered, Moab's southern border.
- g (15:8) Eglaim, "two pools"; Beer-elim, "well of the mighty ones" or "well of the terebinths."
- h (15:9) Dimon, probably a wordplay on Dibon (verse 2) with dam, "blood." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Dibon" (as the Latin Vulgate), while 1QIsa-b agrees with the traditional Hebrew text ("Dimon"); the Septuagint also has Dimon.

Chapter 16

1 Send lambs as tribute to the ruler of the country,
from Sela, through the desert,
to the mountain of Zion's daughter.[a]
2 And like fluttering birds,
like a scattered nest,

so shall the daughters of Moab be
at the fords of the Arnon.[b]
3 "Give counsel, render a decision;
make your shadow as the night
in the midst of the noonday;
conceal the banished;
do not reveal the wanderer.
4 Let my outcasts sojourn with you;
as for Moab, be a refuge to them from the destroyer."
When the oppressor has come to an end,
destruction has ceased,
and he who tramples under foot is consumed out of the land,[c]
5 then a throne shall be established in steadfast love,
and one shall sit on it in faithfulness
in the tent of David,
judging and seeking justice,
and swift to do righteousness.[d]
6 We have heard about Moab's pride—
how extremely proud he is—
his conceit, his pride and his rage;
his empty boasts are false.[e]
7 Therefore let Moab wail for Moab,
let every one wail;
for the raisin cakes of Kir-hareseth
you shall moan, utterly stricken.[f]
8 For the fields of Heshbon languish,
the vine of Sibmah;
the lords of the nations have struck down its choice branches,
which reached to Jazer,
which strayed into the wilderness;
its shoots spread out,
they crossed over the sea.[g]
9 Therefore I weep with the weeping of Jazer
for the vine of Sibmah;
I drench you with my tears,

O Heshbon and Elealeh;
for upon your summer fruit and upon your harvest
the shout has fallen.[h]
10 Gladness and joy have been removed from the orchards;
no one sings or shouts in the vineyards;
no one treads out wine in the presses;
I have ended the shouting.
11 So my bowels moan like a harp for Moab,
and my inward being for Kir-heres.[i]
12 And it shall come to pass, when Moab appears, when he wearies himself on the high place, and comes to his sanctuary to pray, that he shall not prevail.
13 This is the word that Yahweh spoke concerning Moab in time past. 14 But now Yahweh has spoken, saying, "Within three years, as the years of a hired worker, the glory of Moab shall be brought into contempt, with all his great multitude; and the remnant shall be very small and feeble."[j]

Notes

- a (16:1) Sela, "rock," a stronghold of Edom (perhaps near later Petra), where the fugitives of Moab have fled. The Hebrew of this verse is difficult; Moab is apparently urged to send tribute to Jerusalem, as Moab's king once sent lambs to Israel (2 Kings 3:4).
- b (16:2) The Arnon, the great gorge of central Moab, running into the Dead Sea.
- c (16:4) "The oppressor," Hebrew hammets, uncertain; perhaps "the extortioner."
- d (16:5) Hebrew hesed, "steadfast love," "loyal kindness," the covenant faithfulness of God. David, "beloved."
- e (16:6) Compare Jeremiah 48:29–30.
- f (16:7) Or "the foundations" (perhaps "men," compare Jeremiah 48:31). Kir-hareseth, "city of potsherds," the chief city of Moab (2 Kings 3:25), probably modern Kerak; compare verse 11, Kir-heres.
- g (16:8) Sibmah and Jazer, towns of northern Moab famous for their vines. The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the words from "the lords of the nations" in verse 8 through "for the vine of Sibmah" in verse 9, probably by a copyist's eye skipping between the two occurrences of "the vine of Sibmah"; 1QIsa-b has them, with the traditional Hebrew text. "The sea," probably the Dead Sea.
- h (16:9) "Shout," Hebrew heydad, the cry of grape treaders, here turned to the battle shout of the enemy (compare Jeremiah 48:33).

- i (16:11) Hebrew “my bowels,” the seat of the emotions. Kir-heres, “city of the sun”(?) or another form of Kir-hareseth (verse 7).
- j (16:14) That is, counting the years exactly, as a hired worker counts the time of his service.

Chapter 17

1 The oracle concerning Damascus.
Behold, Damascus shall cease to be a city,
and shall become a heap of ruins.[a]
2 The cities of Aroer are forsaken;
they shall be for flocks,
which shall lie down, and none shall make them afraid.[b]
3 The fortress shall cease from Ephraim,
and the kingdom from Damascus;
and the remnant of Syria
shall be like the glory of the children of Israel,
says Yahweh of Armies.[c]
4 And it shall come to pass in that day
that the glory of Jacob shall be brought low,
and the fatness of his flesh shall grow lean.
5 It will be like a reaper gathering the standing grain
and cutting the heads with his arm;
it will be like someone gathering leftover heads
in the Valley of Rephaim.[d]
6 Some gleanings will remain,
as when an olive tree is beaten:
two or three olives
high up at the very top,
four or five
on the branches of the fruit tree,
declares Yahweh, the God of Israel.
7 In that day man shall look to his Maker,
and his eyes shall have regard for the Holy One of Israel;
8 and he shall not look to the altars,
the work of his hands,

nor have regard for what his fingers have made,
either the Asherim or the incense altars.[e]
9 In that day their fortified cities shall be
as the forsaken places of the woods and the mountaintops,
that were forsaken before the children of Israel;
and it shall be a waste.[f]
10 For you have forgotten the God of your salvation,
and have not remembered the Rock of your stronghold;
therefore you plant pleasant plants,
and set out slips of a foreign god;[g]
11 in the day of your planting you make them grow,
and in the morning you make your seed blossom;
yet the harvest flees away
in a day of sickness and incurable pain.
12 Listen, a roar from many peoples!
They roar like the roar of the seas.
And the thundering of nations!
They thunder like the thundering of great waters.
13 Nations make a roar like the roar of many waters,
but he rebukes them, and they run far off,
blown along like chaff in the hills,
like tumbleweed in a whirlwind.
14 In the evening, look, terror!
Before dawn, they are gone.
This is the share of those who strip us bare,
the fate of those who rob us.

Notes

- a (17:1) Damascus, the capital of Aram (Syria), taken by Assyria in 732 BC.
- b (17:2) Aroer, "juniper"(?); here perhaps towns east of the Jordan. The Septuagint reads "forsaken for ever."
- c (17:3) Ephraim, the northern kingdom, allied with Damascus (7:1–9).
- d (17:5) The Valley of Rephaim, southwest of Jerusalem, a fertile grain valley.
- e (17:8) Asherim, sacred poles or trees associated with the goddess Asherah.
- f (17:9) The Septuagint reads "the Amorites and the Hivites" for "the wooded heights and the hilltops" (hahoresh vehaamir), which many follow: "like the deserted cities of the Hivites and the Amorites."

- g (17:10) Or “plants of Naaman” (“pleasant one”), perhaps a title of the god Adonis, whose gardens were quickly forced into bloom. “A foreign god,” or “a stranger.”

Chapter 18

1 Ah, land of whirring wings,
which is beyond the rivers of Cush,[a]
2 which sends ambassadors by sea,
in papyrus boats over the water!
Go, fast messengers,
to a nation tall and smooth-skinned,
to a people feared far and wide,
a mighty nation that tramples everything,
whose land is cut by rivers.[b]
3 All you inhabitants of the world,
and you who dwell on the earth,
when a banner is lifted up on the mountains, look!
and when a trumpet is blown, hear!
4 For this is what Yahweh told me:
“I will stay calm and watch from my dwelling,
like shimmering heat in the sunshine,
like a cloud of dew in the heat of the harvest.”[c]
5 For before the harvest, once the blossoming ends
and the flower turns into a ripening grape,
he will trim off the shoots with pruning knives,
and cut down and remove the spreading branches.
6 They shall be left together for the birds of prey of the mountains,
and for the beasts of the earth;
and the birds of prey shall summer on them,
and all the beasts of the earth shall winter on them.
7 At that time a gift shall be brought to Yahweh of Armies
from a people drawn out and polished,
from a people dreaded from their beginning onward,
a nation of strength upon strength and of trampling down,
whose land the rivers divide,
to the place of the name of Yahweh of Armies, Mount Zion.[d]

Notes

- a (18:1) Cush, the land south of Egypt along the Nile (ancient Nubia, modern Sudan), whose rulers controlled Egypt about 715–663 BC. "Whirring wings," perhaps insects, or the sails of ships; the Septuagint reads "you wings of the land of ships."
- b (18:2) Or "tall and smooth," that is, of great height and glossy skin, or clean-shaven. Or "feared near and far." Hebrew qav-qav, "line-line," perhaps "mighty" or "of strange speech" (compare 28:10). The Hebrew is uncertain.
- c (18:4) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "I will be quiet."
- d (18:7) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "from a people" (as does the Septuagint) for "a people," and lacks the first "of Armies."

Chapter 19

1 A message about Egypt.
Look, Yahweh is riding on a fast cloud
and coming to Egypt;
the idols of Egypt will shake before him,
and the heart of Egypt will melt inside it.[a]
2 "I will stir up Egypt against itself:
brother will fight brother,
neighbor will fight neighbor,
city will fight city, kingdom will fight kingdom.
3 And the spirit of Egypt within it shall be emptied out,
and I will confound its counsel;
and they shall seek the idols and the charmers,
and the mediums and the spiritists.[b]
4 And I will give over the Egyptians
into the hand of a harsh master;
and a fierce king shall rule over them,"
says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies.[c]
5 And the waters shall fail from the sea,
and the river shall be parched and dry;
6 and the canals shall stink,
and the streams of Egypt shall dwindle and dry up;
reeds and rushes shall wither.[d]

7 The bare places by the Nile, by the mouth of the Nile,
and every sown field of the Nile,
shall dry up, be driven away, and be no more.[e]
8 And the fishermen shall mourn,
and all who cast a hook into the Nile shall lament,
and those who spread nets upon the waters shall languish.
9 And the workers in combed flax shall be ashamed,
and the weavers of white cloth.[f]
10 And her pillars shall be crushed,
and all who work for wages shall be grieved in soul.[g]
11 The princes of Zoan are utter fools;
the wisest counselors of Pharaoh give senseless counsel.
How can you say to Pharaoh,
"I am a son of the wise,
a son of ancient kings"?[h]
12 Where then are your wise men?
Let them tell you now, and let them know
what Yahweh of Armies has purposed against Egypt.
13 The princes of Zoan have become fools,
the princes of Memphis are deceived;
the cornerstones of her tribes
have led Egypt astray.[i]
14 Yahweh has mingled within her
a spirit of distortion;
and they have caused Egypt to go astray in every work of hers,
as a drunken man staggers in his vomit.
15 Nothing will be accomplished in Egypt
by head or tail, palm branch or reed.[j]
16 In that day Egypt shall be like women, and shall tremble and fear before the shaking of the hand of Yahweh of Armies, which he shakes over it. 17 And the land of Judah shall become a terror to Egypt; every one to whom it is mentioned shall be afraid, because of the purpose of Yahweh of Armies that he purposes against it.

18 In that day there shall be five cities in the land of Egypt that speak
the language of Canaan and swear allegiance to Yahweh of Armies.
One shall be called the City of Destruction.[k]
19 In that day there shall be an altar to Yahweh in the midst of the land
of Egypt, and a pillar to Yahweh at its border.[l] 20 It will serve as a sign
and a witness to Yahweh of Armies in the land of Egypt; when they
cry out to Yahweh because of their oppressors, he will send them a
savior and defender, and he will rescue them.[m] 21 And Yahweh shall
make himself known to Egypt, and the Egyptians shall know Yahweh
in that day, and shall worship with sacrifice and offering, and shall
vow vows to Yahweh and pay them. 22 And Yahweh will strike Egypt,
striking and healing; and they shall return to Yahweh, and he shall
be entreated by them and heal them.
23 On that day there will be a highway from Egypt to Assyria.
Assyrians will come into Egypt and Egyptians into Assyria, and the
Egyptians will worship together with the Assyrians.[n]
24 In that day Israel shall be the third with Egypt and with Assyria,
a blessing in the midst of the earth, 25 whom Yahweh of Armies has
blessed, saying, "Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work
of my hands, and Israel my inheritance."[o]

Notes

- a (19:1) Egypt, Hebrew Mitsrayim.
- b (19:3) Hebrew 'ittim, perhaps "ghosts" or "whisperers"; compare 8:19.
- c (19:4) Hebrew ha'adon, "the Lord." The "harsh master" may be an Assyrian or a Cushite ruler.
- d (19:6) Hebrew "the rivers," the Nile channels and canals of the delta; "streams of Egypt," Hebrew ye'ore matsor, "Nile streams of Matsor," a name for Egypt.
- e (19:7) Hebrew ye'or, the Nile. Or "the reeds by the Nile."
- f (19:9) Or "shall be pale." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and they shall be ashamed."
- g (19:10) Or "her weavers," reading shatoteyha ("her foundations," MT) as a word for weavers. The Hebrew is uncertain.
- h (19:11) Zoan, Greek Tanis, a royal city in the northeast delta. Pharaoh, Egyptian "great house," the title of the king of Egypt.
- i (19:13) Hebrew Noph, Memphis, the ancient capital near modern Cairo.
- j (19:15) See 9:14–15.
- k (19:18) Hebrew 'ir haheres, "city of destruction," perhaps a wordplay. The Great Isaiah Scroll, some Hebrew manuscripts, and the Latin Vulgate read 'ir

haheres (with a different letter), "City of the Sun," that is, Heliopolis (On, Genesis 41:45), the center of sun worship near Memphis. The Septuagint reads "city of Asedek" ("righteousness"). Canaan, the land west of the Jordan; its language, Hebrew.

- l (19:19) A pillar, Hebrew matsevah, a standing stone marking a sacred place.
- m (19:20) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and he will come down" for "and a champion."
- n (19:23) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the second "Egypt" ("and into Assyria").
- o (19:25) Or "my possession."

Chapter 20

1 In the year the Tartan, the commander in chief, came to Ashdod, sent
by Sargon king of Assyria, and attacked Ashdod and captured it,[a] 2 at
that time Yahweh spoke by Isaiah son of Amoz with these words: "Go,
loosen the sackcloth from your hips and take your sandals off." He did
this, walking around stripped and barefoot.[b] 3 And Yahweh said, "As
my servant Isaiah has walked naked and barefoot three years as a sign
and a portent against Egypt and against Cush,[c] 4 so the king of Assyria
will lead away Egypt's prisoners and Cush's exiles, young and old,
naked and barefoot, with their buttocks bare, to Egypt's shame. 5 And
they shall be terrified and put to shame on account of Cush, to which
they looked, and Egypt, in which they gloried.[d] 6 And the inhabitant
of this coastland shall say in that day, 'Behold, such is our hope, to
which we fled for help to be delivered from the king of Assyria; and
we, how shall we escape?'"[e]

Notes

- a (20:1) Tartan, Assyrian turtanu, the title of the commander-in-chief. Ashdod, a Philistine city; its rebellion was crushed in 711 BC. Sargon II, king of Assyria 722–705 BC; Akkadian Sharru-kin, "the true king."
- b (20:2) "Naked," perhaps stripped to a loincloth, as a captive.
- c (20:3) Cush, see 18:1.
- d (20:5) Or "their expectation."
- e (20:6) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "on which we relied" for "to which we fled." "This coastland," probably Philistia and the Mediterranean coast.

Chapter 21

1 A message about the desert by the sea.
Like windstorms that sweep through the Negev,

it comes from the desert,
from a fearsome land.[a]
2 A hard vision has been told to me:
the treacherous deal treacherously,
and the spoiler spoils.
Go up, Elam! Lay siege, Media!
I have made all her groaning cease.[b]
3 For this cause my loins are full of pain;
throes have taken hold on me,
as the throes of a woman giving birth;
I am bent over from what I hear;
I am terrified at what I see.
4 My heart wanders, horror has overwhelmed me;
the evening twilight of my desire
he has made into a trembling for me.[c]
5 They set the table,
spread out the cushions,
and eat and drink.
Get up, you officers,
and oil the shields![d]
6 For thus the Lord has said to me:
"Go, set a watchman;
let him declare what he sees.
7 And if he sees a troop,
horsemen two by two,
a troop of donkeys,
a troop of camels,
he shall heed it closely,
with great heed."[e]
8 Then the lookout shouted like a lion:[f]
"Lord, I stand on the watchtower all day long,
and I am at my post every night.
9 Look, here come men in a chariot,
and riders in pairs!"
Then he answered,

"Babylon has fallen, has fallen!
All the carved images of her gods
lie smashed on the ground."[g]
10 O my threshed one, and son of my threshing floor,
what I have heard from Yahweh of Armies,
the God of Israel, I have declared to you.[h]
11 The oracle concerning Dumah.
One calls to me from Seir,
"Watchman, what of the night?
Watchman, what of the night?"[i]
12 The watchman says:
"Morning comes, and also the night.
If you will inquire, inquire;
come back again."
13 The oracle concerning Arabia.
In the thickets in Arabia you shall lodge,
O caravans of Dedanites.[j]
14 To the thirsty bring water;
the inhabitants of the land of Tema
met the fugitive with bread.[k]
15 For they have fled from the swords,
from the drawn sword,
from the bent bow,
and from the press of battle.
16 For thus the Lord has said to me: "Within a year, as the years of a hired worker, all the glory of Kedar shall come to an end;[l]
17 and the remainder of the number of the archers, the mighty men of the children of Kedar, shall be few; for Yahweh, the God of Israel, has spoken."

Notes

- a (21:1) The wilderness of the sea, probably southern Babylonia by the Persian Gulf ("the Sealand"). The Negev, the dry south of Judah.
- b (21:2) Elam and Media, peoples of Iran who joined the attack on Babylon (539 BC; compare 13:17).
- c (21:4) Or "my mind reels."

- d (21:5) That is, oil the leather shields for battle.
- e (21:7) Or "chariots," as in verse 9; the Hebrew rekhev means a team or riders as well as a chariot.
- f (21:8) Hebrew "And he cried out, a lion." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads haro'eh, "the seer" (or "the watchman"), for 'aryeh, "a lion," the same letters rearranged: "Then the seer cried out." The Septuagint has neither, reading "and call Urias."
- g (21:9) Compare Revelation 14:8; 18:2.
- h (21:10) That is, Israel, beaten out like grain on the threshing floor.
- i (21:11) Dumah, "silence," perhaps an oasis in north Arabia (Genesis 25:14), here with a play on its meaning; the Septuagint reads Idumea (Edom). Seir, the hill country of Edom.
- j (21:13) Dedan, an Arabian trading people (Genesis 10:7; Ezekiel 27:20).
- k (21:14) Tema, an oasis in northwest Arabia (modern Tayma).
- l (21:16) Kedar, "dark," a tribe of north Arabian nomads (Genesis 25:13). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Within three years" (compare 16:14) and Yahweh for 'Adonai ("the Lord").

Chapter 22

1 The oracle concerning the valley of vision.
What troubles you, then, that you are gone up,
every one of you, upon the roofs,[a]
2 you who are full of uproar,
a tumultuous city, an exultant town?
Your slain are not slain with the sword,
nor are they dead in battle.
3 All your leaders have run away as one;
apart from the bow they were made prisoners;
all in you who were found were bound together;
far off had they fled.[b]
4 Therefore I said, "Look away from me;
let me weep bitterly;
do not labor to comfort me
for the destruction of the daughter of my people."
5 For it is a day of uproar, of treading down, and of bewilderment
from the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
in the valley of vision;
a tearing down of the wall,
and a cry for help toward the mountain.[c]

6 And Elam took up the quiver,
with chariots of men and horsemen;
and Kir uncovered the shield.[d]
7 Your best valleys were filled with chariots,
and horsemen took up positions at the gate.
8 He stripped away Judah's defenses;
and on that day you looked
to the weapons in the House of the Forest.[e]
9 And the breaches of David's city you beheld, how many they were;
and you gathered in the waters of the lower pool;
10 and you counted the houses of Jerusalem,
and you broke down the houses to fortify the wall;
11 and a basin you made between the two walls
for the waters of the old pool.
But to him who did it you did not look,
nor did you have regard for him who formed it long ago.[f]
12 And in that day the Lord, Yahweh of Armies,
called to weeping and to mourning,
to baldness and to girding with sackcloth;
13 But instead there was joy and celebration,
cattle being killed and sheep slaughtered,
meat being eaten and wine being drunk:
"Let's eat and drink,
because tomorrow we will be dead."[g]
14 Yahweh of Armies revealed this in my hearing:
"This sin will never be forgiven you until you die,"
says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies.
15 Thus says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies: "Go, get yourself to this steward, to Shebna, who is over the house, and say:[h]
16 'What business do you have here, and who is there for you here,
that you have dug a tomb for yourself here,
cutting your burial place high up
and carving out a resting place in the rock?
17 Behold, Yahweh will hurl you away violently, O man,
and will grasp you firmly,

18 and will surely wind you round and round,
like a ball into a land broad on both hands;
there you shall die,
and there the chariots of your glory shall be,
you disgrace of your lord's house.
19 And I will thrust you from your office,
and from your station he will pull you down.'
20 And it shall come to pass in that day that I will call my servant Eliakim the son of Hilkiah;[i]
21 I will dress him in your robe,
fasten your sash on him,
and entrust your authority to him;
he will act as a father to the people of Jerusalem
and to the house of Judah.
22 And I will lay the key of the house of David upon his shoulder;
and he shall open, and none shall shut;
and he shall shut, and none shall open.[j]
23 And I will fasten him as a peg in a sure place;
and he shall become a throne of honor to his father's house.[k]
24 And they shall hang upon him all the weight of his father's house, the offspring and the issue, every small vessel, from the bowls to all the jars.
25 In that day, says Yahweh of Armies, the peg that was fastened in a sure place shall give way; and it shall be cut down and fall, and the load that was upon it shall be cut off; for Yahweh has spoken."

Notes

- a (22:1) The valley of vision, apparently Jerusalem itself, perhaps the Hinnom or Kidron valley, where prophetic visions were given.
- b (22:3) Or "without a bow (being drawn)."
- c (22:5) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads differently in the last two lines, perhaps "tearing down his holy place upon the mountain" (qodsho ʻal hahar for qir veshoaʻ ʼel hahar). The Hebrew is uncertain; there is wordplay (meqarqar qir).
- d (22:6) Elam, see 21:2; Kir, a land of uncertain location, compare 2 Kings 16:9; Amos 9:7.
- e (22:8) The House of the Forest of Lebanon, Solomon's armory hall (1 Kings 7:2; 10:17).

- f (22:11) Compare 2 Kings 20:20; 2 Chronicles 32:3–5, 30, describing Hezekiah's water works; "the old pool" may be the Siloam pool.
- g (22:13) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 15:32.
- h (22:15) Shebna, a royal official under Hezekiah, later secretary (36:3). His name may be a shortened form of Shebaniah, "Yahweh has returned"(?). "Steward," Hebrew soken.
- i (22:20) Eliakim, "God raises up"; Hilkiah, "my portion is Yahweh." Compare 36:3.
- j (22:22) Compare Revelation 3:7.
- k (22:23) Or "a nail," a tent peg or a wall peg for hanging things.

Chapter 23

1 The oracle concerning Tyre.
Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for it is laid waste, without house, without harbor!
From the land of Kittim it is revealed to them.[a]
2 Be silent, O inhabitants of the coast,
O merchants of Sidon,
whose messengers passed over the sea,
whom they filled.[b]
3 And on many waters
the grain of Shihor, the harvest of the Nile,
was her revenue;
and she was the market of nations.[c]
4 Be ashamed, O Sidon, for the sea has spoken,
the stronghold of the sea, saying:
"I have not labored nor given birth,
I have not reared young men,
nor brought up young women."
5 When the report comes to Egypt,
they shall be in anguish at the report about Tyre.
6 Pass over to Tarshish;
howl, you who dwell on the coast!
7 Is this your joyful city,
whose beginning is of ancient days,
whose own feet bore her far away to dwell abroad?

8 Who has counseled this against Tyre,
the one who gave crowns,
whose dealers were princes,
whose merchants the honorable of the land?
9 Yahweh of Armies has purposed it,
to defile the pride of all glory,
to bring into contempt all the honored of the earth.
10 Pass through your land like the Nile,
O daughter of Tarshish;
there is no restraint any more.[d]
11 He has stretched out his hand over the sea,
he has shaken the kingdoms;
Yahweh has given command concerning Canaan,
to destroy its strongholds.[e]
12 And he said, "You shall no more exult,
O oppressed virgin daughter of Sidon;
arise, pass over to Kittim;
even there you shall have no rest."[f]
13 Behold the land of the Chaldeans!
This is the people that was not;
Assyria appointed it for desert creatures.
They set up their siege towers,
they stripped her palaces,
they made her a ruin.[g]
14 Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for your stronghold is laid waste.
15 And it shall come to pass in that day that Tyre shall be forgotten seventy years, like the days of one king. At the end of seventy years it shall be with Tyre as in the song of the harlot:[h]
16 "Pick up a harp,
walk around the city,
you forgotten prostitute;
play sweetly,
sing song after song,
so that people will remember you."

17 And it shall come to pass at the end of seventy years that Yahweh
will visit Tyre, and she shall return to her hire, and shall play the
harlot with all the kingdoms of the world on the face of the earth.
18 And her merchandise and her hire shall be holy to Yahweh; it shall
not be stored or hoarded; for her merchandise shall be for those who
dwell before Yahweh, for abundant food and for fine clothing.[i]

Notes

- a (23:1) Tyre, Hebrew Tsor, "rock," the great Phoenician port city on an island off the coast of Lebanon. Tarshish, see 2:16. Kittim, Cyprus (from its city Kition), and later the western lands generally. Or "without house, without entering in."
- b (23:2) Sidon, "fishery," the other great Phoenician city, north of Tyre. Or, with the Great Isaiah Scroll, "your messengers passed over the sea"; Hebrew "passing over the sea, they filled you."
- c (23:3) Shihor, a branch of the Nile in the eastern delta (compare Jeremiah 2:18). The grain trade of Egypt passed through Phoenician hands.
- d (23:10) Or "like the Nile," perhaps "overflow your land." Or "there is no harbor (or shipyard) any more." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Work your land" ('ivdi for 'ivri).
- e (23:11) Canaan, here Phoenicia; Phoenicians called themselves Canaanites.
- f (23:12) "Virgin daughter of Sidon," a personification of the city.
- g (23:13) The verse is difficult; some read "the land of the Kittim" (Cyprus) or take it as a gloss pointing to the fall of Babylon. Hebrew ketiv "his siege towers."
- h (23:15) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the words from "Tyre shall be forgotten" through "seventy years it shall be," probably by a copyist's eye skipping from "in that day" to the similar words that follow. "Like the days of one king," perhaps a lifetime.
- i (23:18) Or "for stately clothing."

Chapter 24

1 Behold, Yahweh empties the earth and makes it waste,
and twists its surface,
and scatters its inhabitants.[a]
2 And it shall be, as with the people, so with the priest;
as with the servant, so with his master;
as with the maid, so with her mistress;
as with the buyer, so with the seller;
as with the lender, so with the borrower;
as with the creditor, so with the debtor.

3 The earth shall be utterly emptied and utterly despoiled;
for Yahweh has spoken this word.
4 The earth mourns and withers;
the world languishes and withers;
the high ones of the people of the earth languish.
5 And the earth is defiled under its inhabitants,
for they have transgressed the laws,
changed the statute,
broken the everlasting covenant.[b]
6 So a curse eats away at the earth,
and its people pay for their guilt;
so the earth's inhabitants are scorched,
and only a few people remain.
7 The new wine mourns, the vine languishes,
all the merry-hearted sigh.
8 The mirth of the tambourines ceases,
the noise of those who rejoice ends,
the mirth of the harp ceases.
9 They do not drink wine with a song;
strong drink is bitter to those who drink it.
10 The city of chaos is broken down;
every house is shut up, so that none can enter.[c]
11 In the streets there is crying over the wine;
all gladness has turned to dusk;
the joy of the land has gone into exile.
12 Desolation is left in the city,
and the gate is battered into ruins.
13 For thus it shall be in the midst of the earth among the peoples,
as at the beating of an olive tree,
as at the gleanings when the grape harvest is done.
14 They lift up their voice, they sing for joy;
over the majesty of Yahweh they shout from the west.[d]
15 So in the east, give glory to Yahweh,
and in the coasts of the sea, give glory to the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel.[e]

16 From the end of the earth we hear songs:
"Splendor for the righteous!"
But I said, "Leanness to me, leanness to me! Alas for me!
The treacherous deal treacherously;
yes, the treacherous deal very treacherously."[f]
17 Dread and pitfall and trap
are upon you who dwell in the land![g]
18 And it shall be that whoever flees from the noise of the dread shall fall into the pitfall,
and whoever comes up from the midst of the pitfall shall be taken in the trap.
For the windows from on high are opened,
and the foundations of the land quake.
19 Broken, broken down is the land;
shattered, shattered is the land;
tottering, tottering is the land.
20 Reeling, the land reels like a drunkard,
and it sways to and fro like a hut;
and its transgression lies heavy upon it,
and it falls, and shall not rise again.[h]
21 On that day Yahweh will call to account the heavenly powers on high
and the kings of the earth on earth.
22 And they shall be gathered together as prisoners in a pit,
and shall be shut up in a prison,
and after many days they shall be punished.[i]
23 Then the moon shall be confounded, and the sun ashamed;
for Yahweh of Armies shall reign
on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem,
and before his elders shall be glory.[j]

Notes

- a (24:1) Chapters 24–27 are often called the "Isaiah Apocalypse." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads ha'adamah, "the ground," for ha'arets, "the earth."
- b (24:5) Or "they have passed by the laws." Compare Genesis 9:16, the covenant with Noah.

- c (24:10) Hebrew tohu, the "formless" emptiness of Genesis 1:2.
- d (24:14) Hebrew "from the sea," that is, the Mediterranean, the west.
- e (24:15) Hebrew "in the lights," perhaps the regions of sunrise; some read "in the coastlands."
- f (24:16) Hebrew razi li, razi li, "my leanness to me"; the sense is uncertain. Or "I have a secret." The Hebrew has a heavy wordplay: bogedim bagadu uveged bogedim bagadu.
- g (24:17) Hebrew pahad vapahath vapah, a wordplay. Compare Jeremiah 48:43–44.
- h (24:20) Or "like a watchman's lodge" in a field (compare 1:8).
- i (24:22) Or "visited." The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the verb "gathered together."
- j (24:23) Hebrew "the white one (the moon) … the hot one (the sun)." Compare Revelation 21:23.

Chapter 25

1 O Yahweh, you are my God;
I will exalt you, I will praise your name;
for you have done wonders,
counsels from long ago, faithfulness and truth.[a]
2 For you have made of a city a heap,
of a fortified town a ruin;
a stronghold of strangers, so that it is no city;
it shall never be rebuilt.
3 Therefore a strong people shall glorify you;
the city of ruthless nations shall fear you.
4 For you have been a fortress for the lowly,
a fortress for the needy in his trouble,
a refuge from the tempest, a shadow from the heat;
when the blast of the terrible ones is as a rainstorm on a wall,
5 like heat in a parched place.
The tumult of strangers you bring down;
as heat by the shadow of a cloud,
so the song of the ruthless is brought low.
6 And in this mountain Yahweh of Armies will make for all peoples
a feast of rich foods, a feast of aged wines,
of rich foods full of marrow,
of aged wines well refined.[b]

7 And he will swallow up in this mountain
the face of the covering that is cast over all peoples,
and the veil that is woven over all nations.[c]
8 He will destroy death forever,
and the Lord Yahweh will wipe the tears from all faces;
he will take away the shame of his people from the entire earth,
because Yahweh has spoken.[d]
9 On that day people will say,
"Look, this is our God;
we waited for him, and he saved us.
This is Yahweh; we waited for him;
let's celebrate and be glad that he saves."[e]
10 For on this mountain the hand of Yahweh shall rest;
and Moab shall be threshed under him,
as straw is threshed in the water of a dung heap.[f]
11 He will stretch out his hands in the middle of it
like a swimmer stretching out to swim,
but Yahweh will lower his pride
along with the skill of his hands.[g]
12 And the lofty stronghold of your walls he has brought down,
he has laid it low, he has made it touch the earth, even the dust.

Notes

- a (25:1) Or "plans formed long ago, in perfect faithfulness."
- b (25:6) Hebrew shemanim, "fat things"; shemarim, "lees," wine aged on its sediment.
- c (25:7) Or "the shroud," a covering of mourning or death.
- d (25:8) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 15:54; compare Revelation 7:17; 21:4.
- e (25:9) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "And you shall say," and adds "Yahweh" after "this is our God."
- f (25:10) Hebrew madmenah, "dung pit," perhaps a wordplay on the Moabite town Madmen (Jeremiah 48:2). Ketiv "in the waters of"; qere "in the dung."
- g (25:11) Or "despite the skill of his hands."

Chapter 26

1 On that day this song will be sung in Judah:
"We have a strong city;
he makes salvation its walls and outer defenses.[a]
2 Open the gates,
that the righteous nation which keeps faithfulness may enter in.[b]
3 The mind that is stayed on you
you keep in perfect peace,
because he trusts in you.[c]
4 Trust in Yahweh forever,
for in Yah, Yahweh, is an everlasting rock.[d]
5 He has humbled those living on the heights,
the city that stood so high;
he brings it down, brings it down to the ground,
and throws it in the dust.
6 The foot tramples it,
the feet of the afflicted,
the steps of the poor."
7 The path of the righteous is level;
you, O Upright One, make smooth the course of the righteous.[e]
8 Yes, Yahweh, as your judgments unfold,
we wait for you;
the longing of our soul
is for your name and the remembrance of you.[f]
9 With my soul I have longed for you in the night;
yes, with my spirit within me I seek you early;
for when your judgments are in the earth,
the inhabitants of the world learn righteousness.
10 If the wicked are shown mercy,
they still do not learn what is right;
even in a land of honest people they act unjustly
and pay no attention to Yahweh's majesty.

11 O Yahweh, your hand is lifted up, yet they do not see;
let them see your zeal for your people, and be ashamed;
yes, let the fire for your adversaries consume them.[g]
12 O Yahweh, you will establish peace for us,
for indeed all our works you have done for us.
13 O Yahweh our God,
lords other than you have been masters over us;
but by you only do we make mention of your name.
14 They are dead, they shall not live;
they are shades, they shall not rise;
therefore you have visited and destroyed them,
and made every memory of them perish.[h]
15 You have enlarged the nation, Yahweh;
you have enlarged the nation and been glorified;
you have pushed out all the borders of the land.
16 O Yahweh, in trouble they came looking for you;
they poured forth a muttered prayer
when your chastening lay on them.[i]
17 As a woman with child,
who draws near the time of her delivery,
writhes and cries out in her pangs,
so have we been before you, O Yahweh.
18 We were with child, we writhed,
we have as it were given birth to wind;
we have not wrought deliverance in the land,
nor have inhabitants of the world been born.[j]
19 Your dead will live; their bodies will rise.
Wake up and sing for joy, you who lie in the dust!
For your dew is like the dew of the morning,
and the earth will bring the departed to birth.[k]
20 Come, my people, enter your chambers,
and shut your doors behind you;
hide yourself for a little moment,
until the indignation passes by.[l]

21 For behold, Yahweh is coming out of his place
to punish the inhabitants of the earth for their iniquity;
and the earth shall disclose her blood,
and shall no more cover her slain.

Notes

- a (26:1) Or "he sets up salvation for walls and bulwark."
- b (26:2) Or "that keeps faith."
- c (26:3) Hebrew shalom shalom, "peace, peace," a doubling for completeness. Or "The steadfast mind you keep in peace."
- d (26:4) Yah, a short form of the name Yahweh (compare 12:2). Rock, Hebrew tsur, a frequent title of God.
- e (26:7) Or "The path of the righteous is uprightness."
- f (26:8) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "and for your law" (ulethoratekha) for "and for your remembrance."
- g (26:11) Or "they shall see your zeal for the people."
- h (26:14) Shades, Hebrew repha'im, the spirits of the dead (compare 14:9).
- i (26:16) Or "they poured out a charm." The Hebrew of the verse is difficult.
- j (26:18) Or "nor have inhabitants of the world fallen." Hebrew naphal, "to fall," perhaps meaning "be born" here.
- k (26:19) "My corpses," Hebrew nevelathi; some read "their corpses." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "they shall awake and shout for joy." "Dew of lights," or "dew of herbs." This is one of the clearest Old Testament expressions of the hope of resurrection (compare Daniel 12:2).
- l (26:20) Compare Exodus 12:22–23.

Chapter 27

1 In that day Yahweh will visit with his sword, the hard and the great and the strong, upon Leviathan the gliding serpent, and upon Leviathan the coiling serpent; and he will kill the monster that is in the sea.[a]

2 In that day:
"A vineyard of wine, sing of it![b]

3 I, Yahweh, am its keeper;
every moment I water it;
lest any harm it,
I keep it night and day.

4 I have no wrath.
Would that I had briers and thorns!

In battle I would stride against them,
I would set them on fire together.[c]
5 Or else let him take hold of my strength,
let him make peace with me;
peace let him make with me."
6 In days to come Jacob shall take root;
Israel shall blossom and bud,
and fill the face of the world with fruit.
7 Has he struck him as he struck those who struck him?
Or is he slain as those were slain who slew him?
8 By measure, by sending her away, you contended with her;
he removed her with his fierce blast in the day of the east wind.[d]
9 So this is how Jacob's guilt will be forgiven,
and this is the full result of removing his sin:
he will crush all the altar stones
like chalk ground to bits,
and no Asherah poles or incense altars will be left standing.[e]
10 For the fortified city is solitary,
a habitation forsaken and deserted like the wilderness;
there the calf grazes, and there it lies down,
and strips its branches.
11 When its branches dry up, they are broken off;
women come and use them as firewood.
This is a people without understanding;
so their Maker will not pity them,
and the one who formed them will not be kind to them.
12 And it shall come to pass in that day that Yahweh will thresh out the grain from the flowing River to the Brook of Egypt, and you shall be gleaned one by one, O children of Israel.[f]
13 On that day a great trumpet will be blown, and the people who were perishing in Assyria and the ones scattered in Egypt will come and bow down to Yahweh on the holy mountain at Jerusalem.[g]

Notes

- a (27:1) Leviathan, a sea monster of chaos; the same descriptions ("fleeing serpent," "twisting serpent") are used of Lotan in Ugaritic texts from about 1300 BC. Compare Job 41:1; Psalm 74:14; 104:26.
- b (27:2) Some Hebrew manuscripts read "A pleasant vineyard" (hemed for hemer); compare 5:1–7.
- c (27:4) Or "Who will give me briers and thorns in battle?"
- d (27:8) Hebrew besa'se'ah, of uncertain meaning, perhaps "by measure" (from se'ah, a dry measure) or "by driving her out."
- e (27:9) Compare Romans 11:27. Asherim, wooden cult poles for the goddess Asherah.
- f (27:12) The River, the Euphrates. The Brook of Egypt, the Wadi el-Arish, the southwest border of Canaan.
- g (27:13) Compare Matthew 24:31; 1 Corinthians 15:52; 1 Thessalonians 4:16.

Chapter 28

1 Woe to the proud crown of the drunkards of Ephraim,
and to the fading flower of its glorious beauty,
which is on the head of the rich valley
of those struck down by wine![a]
2 Look, the Lord has someone strong and powerful;
like a hailstorm and a destructive windstorm,
like a flood of mighty overflowing water,
he throws it down to the ground with his hand.[b]
3 With feet shall be trodden down
the proud crown of the drunkards of Ephraim;
4 and the fading flower of its glorious beauty,
which is on the head of the rich valley,
shall be as an early fig before the summer,
which, when one sees it, he swallows it
while it is still in his hand.
5 In that day Yahweh of Armies shall be a crown of glory
and a diadem of beauty
to the remnant of his people,
6 and a spirit of justice to him who sits in judgment,
and strength to those who turn back the battle at the gate.
7 These men also stumble from wine
and wobble from liquor;

priest and prophet stumble from liquor,
they are confused by wine,
they wobble from liquor;
they stumble when they see visions,
they trip when they give rulings.
8 For all tables are full of vomit and filth,
without a clean place.
9 "Whom will he teach knowledge,
and whom will he make to understand the message?
Those weaned from milk,
those taken from the breast?
10 For it is tsav latsav, tsav latsav,
qav laqav, qav laqav,
a little here, a little there."[c]
11 Truly, with stammering lips and with another tongue
he will speak to this people,[d]
12 to whom he said,
"This is the rest; give rest to the weary;
and this is the repose";
yet they were not willing to hear.
13 Therefore the word of Yahweh shall be to them
tsav latsav, tsav latsav,
qav laqav, qav laqav,
a little here, a little there,
that they may go and fall backward,
and be broken, and snared, and taken.
14 Therefore hear the word of Yahweh, you scoffers,
who rule this people that is in Jerusalem!
15 Because you have said, "We have made a covenant with death,
and with Sheol we have made a pact;
when the overflowing scourge passes through,
it shall not come to us;
for we have made a lie our refuge,
and in falsehood we have hidden ourselves";[e]

16 So the Lord Yahweh says this:
"See, in Zion I am placing a stone as a foundation,
proven, a valuable cornerstone for a secure base;
anyone who trusts in it will not be shaken.[f]
17 And I will make justice the line,
and righteousness the plummet;
and hail shall sweep away the refuge of lies,
and waters shall overflow the hiding place.
18 Then your covenant with death shall be annulled,
and your pact with Sheol shall not stand;
when the overflowing scourge passes through,
you shall be trampled down by it.
19 As often as it passes through it shall take you;
for morning by morning it shall pass through,
by day and by night;
and it shall be sheer terror to understand the message."[g]
20 For the couch is shorter than a man can stretch out upon,
and the blanket narrower than he can wrap himself in.
21 For Yahweh shall rise up as at Mount Perazim;
he shall be stirred as in the valley of Gibeon,
that he may do his work, his strange work,
and bring to pass his act, his foreign act.[h]
22 Now therefore do not be scoffers,
lest your bonds be made strong;
for I have heard a decree of destruction
from the Lord, Yahweh of Armies, upon the whole land.[i]
23 Give ear, and hear my voice;
listen, and hear my speech.
24 Does the plowman plow all day to sow?
Does he open and harrow his ground?
25 When he has leveled its surface,
does he not cast abroad the dill, and fling the cumin,
and set the wheat in rows,
and the barley in its marked place,
and spelt as its border?[j]

26 For his God instructs him rightly;
he teaches him.
27 For not with a sharp sledge is dill threshed,
nor is the wheel of a wagon turned about upon the cumin;
but with a stick is the dill knocked out,
and the cumin with a staff.
28 Bread grain is ground fine,
yet not forever does one keep threshing it;
and though the wheel of his wagon and his horses roll over it,
he does not grind it to powder.[k]
29 This also comes forth from Yahweh of Armies;
he is wonderful in counsel,
and great in sound wisdom.[l]

Notes

- a (28:1) Ephraim, here the northern kingdom of Israel, whose capital Samaria stood on a hill above a fertile valley (about 724 BC). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "the crown of the pride of."
- b (28:2) The mighty one is the king of Assyria. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads Yahweh for 'Adonai ("the Lord").
- c (28:10) Hebrew tsav latsav, tsav latsav, qav laqav, qav laqav, perhaps mocking imitation of the prophet as baby talk, or the letters of the alphabet (tsade, qoph), or "precept upon precept, line upon line."
- d (28:11) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 14:21. The "other tongue" is the Assyrian language.
- e (28:15) Sheol, the realm of the dead. "Death" may also refer to the Canaanite god Mot (death).
- f (28:16) Quoted with Isaiah 8:14 in Romans 9:33; also Romans 10:11; 1 Peter 2:6. "Shall not hasten," that is, shall not panic or flee; the Septuagint reads "shall by no means be put to shame."
- g (28:19) Or "to understand the message shall be sheer terror."
- h (28:21) Compare 2 Samuel 5:20 (Baal-perazim, "lord of breaking through") and Joshua 10:10–14 (Gibeon); there Yahweh fought for Israel, here against it.
- i (28:22) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks 'Adonai, reading "from Yahweh of Armies."
- j (28:25) Dill, Hebrew qetsah, black cumin or nigella. Spelt, a hardy kind of wheat. Hebrew "barley in its place," a word of uncertain meaning (nisman).
- k (28:28) Or "Grain for bread is threshed."
- l (28:29) Or "great in success."

Chapter 29

1 Woe, Ariel, Ariel,
the city where David encamped!
Add year to year;
let the feasts run their round.[a]
2 Then I will distress Ariel,
and there shall be mourning and lamentation,
and she shall be to me like an altar hearth.[b]
3 I will set up camp all around you,
surround you with a siege mound,
and build siege towers against you.[c]
4 And brought low, you shall speak from the earth,
and your speech shall be low from the dust;
and your voice shall be from the earth like that of a ghost,
and your speech shall chirp from the dust.
5 But the crowd of your enemies will be like fine dust,
and the horde of tyrants like drifting chaff;
and it will happen in an instant, all at once.[d]
6 From Yahweh of Armies you shall be visited
with thunder and with earthquake and great noise,
with whirlwind and tempest,
and the flame of a devouring fire.
7 The crowd of all the nations that fight against Ariel,
all who attack her and her fortress and press hard on her,
will be like a dream, a vision in the night.[e]
8 It shall be as when a hungry man dreams,
and behold, he is eating,
and he awakes, and his soul is empty;
or as when a thirsty man dreams,
and behold, he is drinking,
and he awakes, and behold, he is faint,
and his soul is still craving;
so shall the multitude of all the nations be
that fight against Mount Zion.

9 Pause and be astonished;
blind yourselves and go blind!
They are intoxicated, though not by wine;
they stumble, though not by liquor.[f]
10 For Yahweh has poured over you a spirit of deep sleep,
has closed your eyes, you prophets,
and veiled your heads, you seers.[g]
11 For you the entire vision has turned into the content of a sealed scroll. If it is given to a person who can read, with the words "Read this, please," he replies, "I am unable to, since it is sealed."
12 And the book is given to one who does not know writing, saying, "Read this, please"; and he says, "I do not know writing."
13 And the Lord said:
"Because this people draws near with its mouth,
and with its lips they honor me,
but its heart it has removed far from me,
and their fear of me is a commandment of men learned by rote;[h]
14 therefore behold, I will again deal wonderfully with this people,
wonderfully and with wonder;
and the wisdom of their wise men shall perish,
and the understanding of their discerning men shall hide itself."[i]
15 Woe to those who go deep to hide their counsel from Yahweh,
whose deeds are in the dark,
and who say, "Who sees us? And who knows us?"
16 Your perversity!
Is the potter to be reckoned like the clay,
that the work should say of the one who made it, "He made me not";
or the vessel say of the one who shaped it, "He understands nothing"?[j]
17 In just a very short time,
will Lebanon not become an orchard,
and the orchard be thought of as a forest?[k]
18 And in that day the deaf shall hear the words of a book,
and out of gloom and darkness the eyes of the blind shall see.

19 The humble will find new joy in Yahweh,
and the poorest people will celebrate in the Holy One of Israel.
20 For the ruthless shall come to nothing, and the scoffer shall cease,
and all who watch for iniquity shall be cut off,
21 They declare a person guilty by a word,
set a trap for the one who argues at the city gate,
and deny justice to the innocent with groundless claims.[l]
22 Therefore this is what Yahweh, who ransomed Abraham, says about the house of Jacob:
"Jacob will not be put to shame now,
and his face will not be pale with fear now.
23 For when he sees his children,
the work of my hands, in his midst,
they shall sanctify my name;
yes, they shall sanctify the Holy One of Jacob,
and shall stand in awe of the God of Israel.
24 And those who err in spirit shall come to understanding,
and those who murmur shall learn instruction."

Notes

- a (29:1) Ariel, a name for Jerusalem, perhaps meaning "altar hearth" (as in Ezekiel 43:15–16) or "lion of God." Compare 2 Samuel 5:6–9.
- b (29:2) Hebrew ka'ari'el, "like an Ariel," a wordplay: the city shall become a place of burning like an altar.
- c (29:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "with strongholds" (metsodoth). Hebrew "like a circle" (kaddur); the Septuagint reads "like David" (kedawid).
- d (29:5) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "your arrogant ones" (zedayikh) for "your foes" (zarayikh, "your strangers").
- e (29:7) Or "her siege works."
- f (29:9) Or "Delay, and be astonished." Hebrew hitmahmehu utemahu, hishta'ash'u washo'u, a wordplay.
- g (29:10) "The prophets" and "the seers" may be explanatory additions.
- h (29:13) Quoted, following the Septuagint ("in vain do they worship me, teaching the commandments and doctrines of men"), in Matthew 15:8–9; Mark 7:6–7.
- i (29:14) Quoted in 1 Corinthians 1:19, following the Septuagint ("I will destroy … I will set aside").
- j (29:16) Compare Romans 9:20–21; 45:9.
- k (29:17) Hebrew karmel, "garden land" or "orchard."
- l (29:21) Or "with emptiness" (tohu); "in the gate," where justice was administered.

Chapter 30

1 “Woe to the rebellious children,” says Yahweh,
“who carry out a plan, but not mine,
and who pour out a libation, but not of my Spirit,
that they may add sin to sin;[a]
2 who set out to go down to Egypt,
and have not asked my mouth,
to make themselves strong in the strength of Pharaoh,
and to hide in the shade of Egypt!
3 Therefore the strength of Pharaoh shall turn to your shame,
and the hiding in the shade of Egypt to your confusion.
4 For his princes are at Zoan,
and his envoys reach Hanes.[b]
5 They all shall be ashamed
because of a people who cannot profit them,
neither for help nor for profit,
but for shame and also reproach.”
6 A message about the animals of the Negev.
Through a land of hardship and distress,
where lioness and lion roam, and viper and flying fiery serpent live,
they load their wealth on young donkeys
and their treasures on camels’ humps,
to take to a people who cannot help them.[c]
7 For Egypt helps with vanity and to no purpose;
therefore have I named this one
“Rahab, they sit idle.”[d]
8 Now go, write it before them on a tablet,
and inscribe it in a book,
that it may be for the time to come,
a witness forever.[e]
9 For this is a people of rebellion, sons who lie,
sons who will not hear the law of Yahweh;[f]

10 who say to the seers, “Do not see,”
and to the visionaries, “Do not envision for us what is right;
speak to us smooth things,
envision illusions;
11 leave the way, turn aside from the path,
make the Holy One of Israel cease from before us.”
12 Therefore thus says the Holy One of Israel:
“Because you despise this word,
and trust in oppression and crookedness,
and lean upon them,
13 so this guilt will be for you
like a crack about to give way,
bulging in a high wall
that collapses all at once, in a moment;
14 and he will break it as a potter’s jar is broken,
smashed without sparing,
so that there shall not be found among its pieces a potsherd
to carry fire from the hearth,
or to skim water from the pit.”
15 For thus says the Lord Yahweh, the Holy One of Israel:
“By turning back and by resting you shall be saved;
in being quiet and in confidence shall your might be.”
But you were not willing,
16 and you said, “No! for we will flee upon horses”;
therefore you shall flee;
and, “Upon the swift will we ride”;
therefore swift shall they be who chase you.
17 A thousand will run away from the threat of a single one;
you will run away from the threat of five,
until you are left like a pole on a mountaintop,
like a banner on a hill.
18 And therefore Yahweh waits to be gracious to you,
and therefore he rises up to have mercy on you;
for Yahweh is a God of justice;
blessed are all who wait for him.[g]

19 Yes, a people will settle in Zion, in Jerusalem;
your weeping will end.
When you call for help, he will certainly show you kindness;
when he hears you, he will respond.[h]
20 Though the Lord has given you bread of hardship
and water of suffering,
your Teacher will no longer hide himself,
but you will see your Teacher with your own eyes.[i]
21 And when you go to the right hand or to the left,
your ears shall hear a word from behind you, saying,
"This is the way; walk in it."
22 You will treat as unclean your carved images covered in silver
and your cast idols plated in gold;
you will throw them away like filthy rags;
you will tell them, "Get out!"
23 And he will give rain for your seed
with which you sow the ground,
and bread, the produce of the ground,
and it shall be rich and plenteous.
In that day your cattle shall graze in a broad pasture;
24 and the oxen and the young donkeys that till the soil
shall eat salted fodder,
which has been winnowed with shovel and fork.
25 And upon every high mountain and upon every lofty hill
there shall be channels running with water,
in the day of the great slaughter, when the towers fall.
26 And the light of the moon shall be as the light of the sun,
and the light of the sun shall be sevenfold,
as the light of seven days,
in the day when Yahweh binds up the brokenness of his people,
and heals the wounds inflicted by his blow.
27 Behold, the name of Yahweh comes from afar,
burning with his anger, and heavy rising smoke;
his lips are full of indignation,
and his tongue is like a devouring fire;[j]

28 and his breath is like a flooding river
rising to the neck,
to shake the nations in a sieve of ruin,
with a bridle in the jaws of the peoples that leads them astray.
29 You shall have a song as in the night when a holy feast is kept,
and gladness of heart, as when one goes with the flute
to come to the mountain of Yahweh, to the Rock of Israel.
30 And Yahweh will cause the majesty of his voice to be heard,
and will show the descending blow of his arm,
in furious anger and the flame of a devouring fire,
with cloudburst and storm and hailstones.
31 For at the voice of Yahweh Assyria shall be shattered,
when he strikes with the rod.
32 And every stroke of the appointed staff
which Yahweh lays upon him
shall be to the sound of tambourines and lyres;
and in battles of brandishing he will fight with them.[k]
33 A Topheth has been ready for a long time;
it has been prepared for the king as well;
its fire pit is made deep and wide,
with plenty of fire and wood;
the breath of Yahweh, like a stream of burning sulfur, sets it on fire.[l]

Notes

- a (30:1) Or "who make an alliance" (literally "weave a web").
- b (30:4) Zoan, see 19:11. Hanes, probably Heracleopolis, south of Memphis, or a town in the delta. "His," perhaps Pharaoh's, or Judah's.
- c (30:6) The Negev, the dry land south of Judah, through which envoys traveled to Egypt. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "of trouble and dryness and anguish, of lioness and lion, and there is no water." "Flying fiery serpent," see 14:29.
- d (30:7) Rahab, "arrogance" or "storm," the name of a chaos monster and a name for Egypt (51:9; Psalm 87:4). Hebrew rahav hem shavet, perhaps "Rahab, they are a do-nothing."
- e (30:8) Or, with some Hebrew vocalizations and ancient versions, "as a witness."
- f (30:9) Hebrew torah, "law" or "teaching."
- g (30:18) Or "Yahweh longs to be gracious to you."
- h (30:19) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds Yahweh ("Yahweh will surely be gracious").
- i (30:20) Or "your teachers." The Hebrew moreyka may be singular or plural.

- j (30:27) Or "and his burden is heavy."
- k (30:32) Or "with them he will fight in battles of wave offering," a phrase for brandishing.
- l (30:33) Topheth, a place of burning in the Valley of Hinnom where children were sacrificed (2 Kings 23:10; Jeremiah 7:31). Some read "for Molech" in place of "for the king" (Hebrew lammelek), a wordplay.

Chapter 31

1 How terrible for those who go down to Egypt to get help,
who depend on horses
and put their confidence in the vast number of chariots
and in the great strength of the horsemen,
but never look to the Holy One of Israel
or ask Yahweh for guidance!
2 Yet he too is wise, and brings disaster,
and does not call back his words,
but will arise against the house of evildoers,
and against the help of those who work iniquity.
3 And the Egyptians are men, and not God,
and their horses flesh, and not spirit.
When Yahweh stretches out his hand,
the helper shall stumble, and the one helped shall fall,
and they shall all perish together.[a]
4 For thus Yahweh has said to me:
"As the lion and the young lion roar over their catch,
and though a crowd of herdsmen be summoned against him,
he is not dismayed at their shouting
nor cowed by their noise,
so shall Yahweh of Armies come down
to wage war upon Mount Zion and upon its hill.
5 Like birds hovering,
so will Yahweh of Armies shield Jerusalem;
he will shield and deliver it,
he will pass over and rescue it."[b]
6 Turn back to him against whom the children of Israel have deeply revolted.[c]

7 For in that day every man shall cast away his idols of silver and his
idols of gold, which your own hands have made for you as sin.
8 "And Assyria shall fall by a sword not of man;
and a sword not of mankind shall devour him;
and he shall flee from the sword,
and his young men shall be put to forced labor.[d]
9 And his rock shall pass away in terror,
and his princes shall be dismayed at the banner,"
says Yahweh, whose fire is in Zion,
and whose furnace is in Jerusalem.[e]

Notes

- a (31:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "lion" (ʾaryeh) for "spirit" (ruah) in verse 3, apparently a correction or slip; compare verse 4.
- b (31:5) Hebrew pasoah, "passing over," the verb of the Passover (Exodus 12:13, 23, 27).
- c (31:6) Or "from whom you have deeply revolted, O children of Israel."
- d (31:8) Compare 37:36.
- e (31:9) "His rock," perhaps his stronghold, or his king.

Chapter 32

1 Behold, a king shall reign in righteousness,
and princes shall rule with justice.
2 Each one will be like a shelter from the wind,
a hiding place from the storm,
like channels of water in a parched land,
like the shadow of a massive boulder in a worn-out land.
3 And the eyes of those who see shall not be closed,
and the ears of those who hear shall give heed.
4 And the heart of the hasty shall understand knowledge,
and the tongue of the stammerers shall hasten to speak plainly.
5 The fool shall no more be called noble,
nor shall the scoundrel be said to be generous.[a]
6 For the fool speaks folly,
and his heart works iniquity,
to practice godlessness,
and to utter error against Yahweh,

to make empty the soul of the hungry,
and to cause the drink of the thirsty to fail.[b]
7 As for the knave, his tools are evil;
he devises wicked devices
to undo the lowly with words of falsehood,
even when the needy speaks what is right.
8 But the generous man devises generous things,
and by generous things shall he stand.
9 Rise up, you women who are at ease, hear my voice;
you complacent daughters, give ear to my speech.
10 In a little more than a year
you shall shudder, you complacent women;
for the grape harvest fails,
the gathering shall not come.[c]
11 Quake, you women at ease;
be troubled, you careless ones;
strip yourselves, lay yourselves bare,
and gird sackcloth upon your loins.[d]
12 They beat upon their breasts
for the pleasant fields, for the fruitful vine,
13 for the ground of my people,
where thorn and brier come up,
yes, upon all the houses of gladness in the merry town.
14 For the palace is forsaken,
the noisy city is deserted;
the hill and the watchtower
shall become caves forever,
a joy of wild donkeys, a pasture of flocks;[e]
15 until the Spirit is poured out upon us from on high,
and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field,
and the fruitful field is counted as a forest.
16 Then justice shall dwell in the wilderness,
and righteousness abide in the fruitful field.
17 And the work of righteousness shall be peace,
and the service of righteousness, quietness and trust forever.

18 My people will live in a peaceful home,
in secure houses, in quiet places of rest.
19 Though hail will fall when the forest is cut down,
and the city will be completely leveled,[f]
20 Blessed are you who sow beside all waters,
who let the foot of the ox and the donkey range free.

Notes

- a (32:5) Hebrew naval, "fool," the morally senseless man (compare 1 Samuel 25:25, Nabal); kilai, "scoundrel" or "knave."
- b (32:6) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "his heart devises iniquity."
- c (32:10) Hebrew "Days upon a year."
- d (32:11) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads the verbs as plural feminine forms and adds "and wail."
- e (32:14) Hebrew 'ophel, the hill of the city of David (compare 2 Chronicles 27:3).
- f (32:19) Or "the forest shall utterly fall." The Hebrew of verse 19 is uncertain.

Chapter 33

1 Woe to you who spoil, and were not spoiled,
and deal treacherously, and they did not deal treacherously with you!
When you have made an end of spoiling, you shall be spoiled;
and when you have finished betraying, they shall betray you.[a]
2 Yahweh, be kind to us; we have waited for you.
Be our strength every morning,
and our rescue in times of trouble.[b]
3 At the sound of tumult the peoples flee;
when you lift yourself up, nations are scattered.
4 Your plunder is gathered like caterpillars gather;
people pounce on it like swarming locusts.
5 Yahweh is exalted, for he dwells on high;
he has filled Zion with justice and righteousness.
6 And there shall be steadiness in your seasons,
riches of deliverance, of wisdom and of knowing;
the fear of Yahweh is his treasure.[c]
7 Behold, their heroes cry outside;
the envoys of peace weep bitterly.[d]

8 The highways lie waste,
the traveler ceases;
the covenant is broken,
the cities are despised,
he has no regard for man.[e]
9 The land mourns and languishes;
Lebanon is abashed and moulders;
Sharon has become like the desert plain,
and Bashan and Carmel shed their foliage.[f]
10 "Now I will arise," says Yahweh;
"now I will be exalted;
now I will be lifted up.
11 You conceive chaff,
you give birth to stubble;
your breath is a fire that shall devour you.
12 And the peoples shall be as burnings of lime,
as thorns cut down, that are burned in the fire.
13 Hear, you who are far off, what I have done;
and you who are near, know my might."
14 The sinners in Zion are afraid;
trembling has seized the godless:
"Who among us can dwell with the devouring fire?
Who among us can dwell with everlasting burnings?"
15 Whoever lives justly and speaks honestly,
who refuses to profit from extortion,
who waves away a bribe instead of taking it,
who blocks his ears against plots of bloodshed,
and shuts his eyes against watching evil,
16 he shall dwell on the heights;
his refuge shall be the fortresses of rocks;
his bread shall be given him,
his water shall be sure.
17 Your eyes shall behold the king in his beauty;
they shall see a land that stretches afar.

18 Your mind will go back over the terror:
"Where is the scribe? Where is the one who weighed out the payment?
Where is the officer who tallied the towers?"[g]
19 The fierce people you shall not see,
a people of speech too deep to perceive,
of a mocking tongue that has no sense to you.
20 Look at Zion, the city of our festivals!
Your eyes will see Jerusalem,
a peaceful home, a tent that will not be moved,
whose pegs will never be pulled up
and none of whose ropes will snap.
21 There Yahweh will be our majestic God,
in a place of wide rivers and streams,
where no rowing ship will travel
and no great vessel will sail.
22 For Yahweh is our judge,
Yahweh is our lawgiver,
Yahweh is our king;
he will save us.[h]
23 Your ropes hang loose;
they cannot hold firm the base of their mast,
nor spread out the sail.
Then prey and spoil in abundance shall be divided;
even the lame shall take the prey.
24 No resident will say, "I am ill";
the people living there will have their guilt forgiven.

Notes

- a (33:1) Probably Assyria; compare 21:2.
- b (33:2) "Their arm," so the Hebrew; some ancient versions read "our arm."
- c (33:6) Or "Zion's treasure."
- d (33:7) Hebrew 'er'ellam, of uncertain meaning; perhaps "their Ariel" (compare 29:1) or "I will appear to them." The Great Isaiah Scroll divides it as 'er'eh lam, "I will see (or appear) to them."
- e (33:8) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads 'edim, "witnesses," for 'arim, "cities": "he has despised the witnesses," perhaps the witnesses to the treaty.

- f (33:9) Sharon, the coastal plain; "the desert plain," Hebrew haʿaravah, the Arabah, the desert rift south of the Dead Sea; Bashan, the fertile highland east of the Sea of Galilee; Carmel, the wooded ridge by the sea (compare 35:2).
- g (33:18) Officials who counted and weighed the tribute and surveyed the defenses. Compare 1 Corinthians 1:20.
- h (33:22) Hebrew mehoqeqenu, "our lawgiver" or "our commander." Compare James 4:12.

Chapter 34

1 Draw near, O nations, to hear,
and give heed, O peoples!
Let the land and its fullness hear,
the world and all its offspring.
2 For Yahweh is angry with all the nations
and furious with all their armies;
he has put them under the ban for destruction
and handed them over to be slaughtered.[a]
3 And their slain shall be cast out,
and the stench of their corpses shall rise,
and the mountains shall melt with their blood.
4 And all the host of heaven shall rot away,
and the heavens shall be rolled up like a scroll;
and all their host shall wither,
as the leaf withers from the vine,
like a withering fig from the fig tree.[b]
5 For my sword has drunk its fill in the heavens;
behold, it comes down upon Edom,
upon the people I have devoted, for judgment.[c]
6 The sword of Yahweh is full of blood,
it is gorged with fat,
with the blood of lambs and goats,
with the fat of the kidneys of rams.
For Yahweh has a sacrifice in Bozrah,
and a great slaughter in the land of Edom.[d]
7 And the wild oxen shall come down with them,
and young bulls with the mighty bulls;

and their land shall be soaked with blood,
and their dust made rich with fat.
8 For it is Yahweh's day of vengeance,
a year of recompense for the cause of Zion.
9 And her streams shall be turned into pitch,
and her dust into brimstone,
and her land shall become burning pitch.
10 It will not be put out night or day;
its smoke will rise forever.
It will lie in ruins from one generation to the next;
no one will ever pass through it again.[e]
11 But the hawk and the hedgehog shall possess it,
and the owl and the raven shall dwell in it;
and he shall stretch over it the line of confusion
and the plummet of emptiness.[f]
12 Her nobles, there is none there whom they proclaim king,
and all her princes shall be nothing.
13 And thorns shall come up in her palaces,
nettles and thistles in her fortresses;
and she shall be a haunt of jackals,
an abode for ostriches.
14 And the wild beasts of the desert shall meet with the hyenas,
and the wild goat shall cry to his fellow;
indeed, there the night creature shall settle,
and find for herself a resting place.[g]
15 There the owl will make her nest and lay her eggs,
hatch them and gather the young under her wings;
there also the vultures will gather,
each with its mate.[h]
16 Seek out of the book of Yahweh, and read:
not one of these shall be missing;
none shall lack her mate.
For his mouth has commanded,
and his Spirit has gathered them.[i]

17 And he has cast the lot for them,
and his hand has divided it to them by measure;
forever shall they hold it as their own;
age after age shall they abide in it.

Notes

- a (34:2) Hebrew heherim, "devoted to destruction" (herem), the ban of holy war.
- b (34:4) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "And the valleys shall be split, and all the host of heaven shall fall" for "And all the host of heaven shall rot away." Compare Matthew 24:29; Revelation 6:13–14.
- c (34:5) Or "the people of my ban." Edom, the people descended from Esau, here standing for the hostile nations. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "shall appear" (tera'eh) for "has drunk its fill" (rivvetah).
- d (34:6) Bozrah, a chief city of Edom (compare 63:1). Compare Revelation 19:13–15.
- e (34:10) Compare Revelation 14:11; 19:3.
- f (34:11) Hebrew tohu and bohu, "formlessness" and "emptiness," as in Genesis 1:2. The identity of several of these creatures is uncertain.
- g (34:14) Hebrew lilith, perhaps a nocturnal bird, or the name of a female night demon known from Mesopotamian sources. "Hyenas," or "howling creatures"; "wild goat," or "goat-demon" (compare 13:21).
- h (34:15) Hebrew qippoz, uncertain, perhaps an owl. Kites, birds of prey.
- i (34:16) Hebrew "my mouth." The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "his mouth."

Chapter 35

1 The wilderness and the dry land shall be glad,
and the desert shall rejoice and blossom like the crocus.[a]
2 It shall blossom abundantly,
and rejoice with joy and singing.
The glory of Lebanon shall be given to it,
the splendor of Carmel and Sharon.
They shall see the glory of Yahweh,
the splendor of our God.
3 Strengthen the slack hands,
and make firm the tottering knees.[b]
4 Say to those who are of an anxious heart,
"Be strong, do not fear!
Behold, your God will come with vengeance,
with the recompense of God;
he will come and save you."

5 Then the eyes of the blind shall be opened,
and the ears of the deaf unstopped;
6 then the lame man shall leap like a deer,
and the tongue of the mute shall sing.
For waters shall break forth in the wilderness,
and streams in the desert;[c]
7 and the burning sand shall become a pool,
and the thirsty ground springs of water;
in the haunt of jackals, where they lay,
grass shall become reeds and rushes.[d]
8 And a highway shall be there, and a way,
and it shall be called the Way of Holiness;
the unclean shall not pass over it;
it shall be for those who walk the way,
and fools shall not wander on it.[e]
9 There will be no lions there,
and no vicious animals will come up on it;
none will be found there;
but the redeemed will walk on it.
10 The ones Yahweh has ransomed will return
and enter Zion singing,
with everlasting joy crowning their heads;
they will be overtaken by gladness and joy,
and sorrow and sighing will run away.[f]

Notes

- a (35:1) Or "like the rose"; Hebrew havatselet, perhaps the crocus or asphodel.
- b (35:3) Compare Hebrews 12:12.
- c (35:6) Compare Matthew 11:5; Luke 7:22.
- d (35:7) Or "the mirage shall become a pool." Hebrew sharav.
- e (35:8) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "and a way." Or "it shall be for them; the wayfarer, even fools, shall not go astray."
- f (35:10) Compare 51:11.

Chapter 36

1 And it came to pass in the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah that Sennacherib king of Assyria came up against all the fortified cities

of Judah and seized them.[a] 2 The king of Assyria sent the Rabshakeh,
his chief officer, with a large army from Lachish to King Hezekiah in
Jerusalem. He stopped at the aqueduct of the upper pool, on the road
to the Launderer's Field.[b] 3 Eliakim son of Hilkiah, who was in charge
of the palace, came out to him, together with Shebna the secretary
and Joah son of Asaph, the recorder.[c]
4 And the Rabshakeh said to them, "Tell Hezekiah, I pray you, 'So
says the great king, the king of Assyria: What trust is this in which
you trust? 5 I say, your counsel and might for war are but a word of
the lips. Now upon whom do you rely, that you have rebelled against
me?[d] 6 Behold, you rely on the staff of this crushed reed, upon Egypt,
which, if a man leans on it, goes into his hand and pierces it. So is
Pharaoh king of Egypt to all who rely on him. 7 But if you say to me,
"In Yahweh our God we trust," is it not he whose high places and
whose altars Hezekiah has removed, and has said to Judah and to
Jerusalem, "Before this altar you shall bow down"? 8 Now therefore,
make a wager, please, with my master the king of Assyria: I will give
you two thousand horses, if you are able on your part to put riders on
them. 9 How then can you turn away even one governor, one of the
least of my master's servants, when you depend on Egypt for chariots
and horsemen? 10 And now, is it without Yahweh that I have come up
against this land to destroy it? Yahweh said to me, Go up against this
land and destroy it.'"
11 Then Eliakim, Shebna and Joah said to the chief officer, "Please
speak to your servants in Aramaic, since we understand it; do not
speak in the language of Judah where the people on the wall can
hear."[e] 12 But the Rabshakeh said, "Is it to your master and to you that
my master has sent me to speak these words? Is it not to the men
sitting on the wall, doomed with you to eat their own dung and to
drink their own urine?" 13 Then the chief officer stood and shouted in
the language of Judah, "Listen to the message of the great king, the
king of Assyria! 14 Thus says the king: 'Do not let Hezekiah deceive
you, for he will not be able to deliver you. 15 And do not let Hezekiah
make you trust in Yahweh, saying, "Yahweh will surely deliver us;
this city shall not be given into the hand of the king of Assyria."' 16

Pay no heed to Hezekiah; for so says the king of Assyria: ‘Make a blessing with me, and come out to me; and eat every one of his own vine and every one of his own fig tree, and drink every one the waters of his own cistern,[f] 17 until I come and take you away to a land like your own land, a land of grain and new wine, a land of bread and vineyards. 18 Beware lest Hezekiah mislead you, saying, “Yahweh will deliver us.” Has any of the gods of the nations delivered his land out of the hand of the king of Assyria? 19 Where are the gods of Hamath and Arpad? Where are the gods of Sepharvaim? And have they delivered Samaria out of my hand?[g] 20 Who among all the gods of these lands have delivered their land out of my hand, that Yahweh should deliver Jerusalem out of my hand?’” 21 But they kept silent and answered him not a word; for the king’s command was, “Do not answer him.” 22 Then Eliakim son of Hilkiah, the palace manager, together with Shebna the secretary and Joah son of Asaph, the recorder, came to Hezekiah. Their clothes were torn, and they reported the chief officer’s words to him.

Notes

- a (36:1) Chapters 36–39 closely parallel 2 Kings 18:13–20:19. The fourteenth year of Hezekiah, 701 BC. Hezekiah, “Yahweh strengthens”; Sennacherib, king of Assyria 705–681 BC, Akkadian Sin-ahhe-eriba, “(the god) Sin has replaced the brothers.” His own annals record the capture of forty-six walled cities of Judah.
- b (36:2) The Rabshakeh, Akkadian rab shaqe, “chief cupbearer,” the title of a high Assyrian official. Lachish, a major fortress city of Judah about 30 miles (48 kilometers) southwest of Jerusalem, whose siege is pictured on Sennacherib’s palace reliefs at Nineveh. The Washer’s Field, see 7:3.
- c (36:3) Joah, “Yahweh is brother”; Asaph, “he gathers.” Compare 22:15–22.
- d (36:5) Hebrew “I say”; 2 Kings 18:20 and the Great Isaiah Scroll read “You say (you have counsel and might …).”
- e (36:11) Aramaic, the international language of diplomacy; Judean, the Hebrew dialect of Judah.
- f (36:16) “Make a blessing,” that is, make peace, surrender.
- g (36:19) Hamath, Arpad, and Sepharvaim, cities of Syria conquered by Assyria (compare 10:9).

Chapter 37

1 And it came to pass, when King Hezekiah heard it, that he tore his garments and covered himself with sackcloth, and went into the

house of Yahweh. 2 And he sent Eliakim, who was over the household, and Shebna the secretary, and the elders of the priests, covered with sackcloth, to Isaiah the prophet, the son of Amoz. 3 They told him, "This is what Hezekiah says: 'Today is a day of anguish, rebuke and disgrace; it is as when children are ready to be born and there is no strength to deliver them.[a] 4 Perhaps Yahweh your God will hear the words of the Rabshakeh, with which his master the king of Assyria sent him to defy the living God, and will rebuke the words that Yahweh your God has heard. Therefore lift up your prayer for the remnant that is left.'"[b] 5 So the servants of King Hezekiah came to Isaiah. 6 Isaiah said to them, "Tell your master this: 'This is what Yahweh says: Do not be afraid of the words you heard, with which the king of Assyria's servants have insulted me.[c] 7 Behold, I will put a spirit in him, and he shall hear a rumor and return to his own land; and I will make him fall by the sword in his own land.'"

8 So the Rabshakeh returned, and found the king of Assyria fighting against Libnah; for he had heard that he had departed from Lachish.[d] 9 Then the king heard a report about Tirhakah king of Cush: "He has marched out to fight you." When Sennacherib heard it, he sent messengers to Hezekiah with this message:[e] 10 "Say this to Hezekiah king of Judah: 'Do not let your God, in whom you trust, fool you by saying, "Jerusalem will not be handed over to the king of Assyria." 11 Behold, you have heard what the kings of Assyria have done to all the lands, devoting them to destruction; and shall you be delivered? 12 Did the gods of the nations deliver them, the nations which my fathers destroyed, Gozan and Haran and Rezeph, and the children of Eden who were in Telassar?[f] 13 Where is the king of Hamath, and the king of Arpad, and the king of the city of Sepharvaim, of Hena, and of Ivvah?'"[g]

14 Hezekiah took the letter from the messengers and read it. Then he went up to Yahweh's house and spread it out before Yahweh. 15 And Hezekiah prayed to Yahweh, saying, 16 "Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel, enthroned above the cherubim, you alone are God over all the kingdoms of the earth; you made heaven and earth.[h] 17 Incline your ear, O Yahweh, and hear; open your eyes, O Yahweh, and see; and

hear all the words of Sennacherib, which he has sent to taunt the living God. 18 Of a truth, O Yahweh, the kings of Assyria have laid waste all the nations and their lands,[i] 19 and have cast their gods into the fire; for they were no gods, but the work of men's hands, wood and stone; so they destroyed them. 20 And now, O Yahweh our God, save us from his hand, that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that you alone are Yahweh."[j]

21 Then Isaiah son of Amoz sent a message to Hezekiah: "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'You have prayed to me about Sennacherib king of Assyria,

22 so this is the word Yahweh has spoken against him:

"Zion's virgin daughter
looks down on you with scorn;
Jerusalem's daughter
shakes her head behind your back.

23 Whom have you taunted and reviled?
And against whom have you raised your voice,
and lifted up your eyes on high?
Against the Holy One of Israel!

24 By your servants you have mocked the Lord,
and have said, 'With my many chariots
I have gone up to the height of the mountains,
to the far recesses of Lebanon;
and I will cut down its tall cedars,
its choicest cypresses;
and I will come to its farthest height,
its densest forest.[k]

25 I have dug and have drunk water,
and I will dry up with the soles of my feet
every river of Egypt.'[l]

26 Have you not heard
that I determined it long ago?
From days of old I formed it;
now I have brought it to pass,

that you should be the one to lay waste walled cities
into ruinous heaps,
27 while their inhabitants, short of hand,
were dismayed and put to shame,
and became like the grass of the field and like the green herb,
like grass on the housetops,
blighted before it is grown.[m]
28 But I know where you stay,
when you leave and when you arrive,
and how you rage against me.
29 Because of your raging against me
and because your arrogance has reached my ears,
I will put my hook in your nose
and my bit between your lips,
and I will send you back by the same road
you traveled on."[n]
30 This will be the sign for you: this year you will eat what grows on its own, and in the second year what springs up from that; but in the third year, sow and harvest, plant vineyards and eat their fruit. 31 And the surviving remnant of the house of Judah shall again take root downward and bear fruit upward. 32 For out of Jerusalem shall go forth a remnant, and survivors out of Mount Zion. The zeal of Yahweh of Armies will do this.[o] 33 Therefore thus says Yahweh concerning the king of Assyria: He shall not come into this city, nor shoot an arrow there, nor come before it with a shield, nor heap up a siege mound against it. 34 By the way that he came, by it he shall return, and into this city he shall not come, says Yahweh. 35 For I will defend this city to save it, for my own sake and for the sake of David my servant.'"
36 Then the angel of Yahweh went out and struck down 185,000 men in the Assyrian camp; and when people got up early in the morning, there they were—all dead bodies.[p] 37 Then Sennacherib king of Assyria departed and went away, and returned and dwelt at Nineveh.[q] 38 One day, while he was worshiping in the temple of his god Nisroch, his sons Adrammelech and Sharezer killed him with the sword and

escaped to the land of Ararat. His son Esarhaddon became king in his place.[r]

Notes

- a (37:3) That is, the crisis has come, but there is no strength to finish it.
- b (37:4) "The remnant that is left," after the Assyrian conquest of the other cities of Judah. The Great Isaiah Scroll adds, as a correction above the line, "in this city."
- c (37:6) "Young men," Hebrew naʿare, a contemptuous word for the king's servants. In the Great Isaiah Scroll, much of verses 4–7 is written as a later correction between the lines.
- d (37:8) Libnah, a town of Judah north of Lachish.
- e (37:9) Tirhakah, Egyptian Taharqa, a king of the Cushite (Nubian) dynasty that ruled Egypt; he became Pharaoh about 690 BC, but led the Egyptian army as a prince in 701 BC. Cush, see 18:1.
- f (37:12) Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, Eden (Bit-Adini), and Telassar, cities and regions in upper Mesopotamia and Syria.
- g (37:13) Hena and Ivvah, unidentified cities. The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "and Samaria."
- h (37:16) Cherubim, winged guardian figures above the ark of the covenant (Exodus 25:18–22).
- i (37:18) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "and their lands"; compare 2 Kings 19:17.
- j (37:20) So 2 Kings 19:19 and the Great Isaiah Scroll, adding "God" ("that you alone are Yahweh God"); the Masoretic Text of Isaiah reads "that you alone are Yahweh."
- k (37:24) Hebrew "the height of its garden land" (karmel).
- l (37:25) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "foreign" ("foreign waters"), as in 2 Kings 19:24. "Streams of Egypt," or "streams of Matsor" (compare 19:6).
- m (37:27) So 2 Kings 19:26 ("blighted," shedephah). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "blighted before the east wind"; the Masoretic Text of Isaiah reads "and a field (shedemah) before the standing grain."
- n (37:29) Compare 30:28.
- o (37:32) The Great Isaiah Scroll reverses Zion and Jerusalem. Compare 9:7.
- p (37:36) Herodotus (2.141) preserves an Egyptian tradition that the Assyrian army was overrun in a night by field mice that gnawed their bowstrings; compare 2 Kings 19:35.
- q (37:37) Nineveh, the Assyrian capital on the Tigris.
- r (37:38) Sennacherib was assassinated in 681 BC, about twenty years later. Nisroch, an unidentified god. Ararat, Urartu, the kingdom north of Assyria in modern Armenia. Esarhaddon, king of Assyria 681–669 BC, Akkadian Ashur-ahu-iddina, "Ashur has given a brother."

Chapter 38

1 About that time Hezekiah fell gravely ill. The prophet Isaiah, Amoz's
son, visited him and told him, "Yahweh says: Set your affairs in order,
because you will die; you will not get well."[a] 2 Then Hezekiah turned
his face toward the wall, and prayed to Yahweh, 3 and said, "Ah,
Yahweh, remember now, I pray, that I have walked before your face
in truth and with a perfect heart, and have done that which was right
in your sight." And Hezekiah wept with great weeping.
4 Then the word of Yahweh came to Isaiah, saying, 5 "Go and say to
Hezekiah, 'Thus says Yahweh, the God of David your father: I have
heard your prayer, I have seen your tears; behold, I am adding fifteen
years to your days. 6 And from the hand of the king of Assyria I will
deliver you and this city, and I will defend this city.[b] 7 And this shall be
the sign to you from Yahweh, that Yahweh will do this thing that he
has spoken: 8 Behold, the shadow on the steps, which has gone down
with the sun on the steps of Ahaz, I will cause to return backward
ten steps.'" So the sun went back ten steps, on the steps where it had
gone down.[c]
9 A writing of Hezekiah king of Judah, when he had been sick and
had recovered from his sickness:[d]
10 I said, In the quiet of my days
I must go into the gates of Sheol;
I am deprived of the rest of my years.[e]
11 I thought, I will not see Yah,
Yah, in the land of the living;
I will no more look at any human being
of those who live in this world.[f]
12 My home is pulled up and carried off from me
as a herdsman's tent is;
I have rolled up my life as a weaver rolls his cloth;
from the loom he severs me;
between day and night you make an end of me.[g]
13 I quieted myself till the morning;
as a lion, so does he crush all my bones;
between day and night you make an end of me.[h]

14 Like a swift or a crane, so I chirp,
I moan like a dove;
my eyes are worn out with looking upward.
O Lord, I am oppressed; be my surety![i]
15 What can I say? He has spoken to me,
and it is he who has done it.
I shall walk slowly all my years
because of the bitterness of my soul.[j]
16 O Lord, by these things men live,
and in all of them is the life of my spirit;
so restore me, and make me live![k]
17 See, it was for my benefit
that I endured such bitter distress;
because you loved me, you kept my soul
from the pit of ruin,
and you tossed all my sins behind your back.[l]
18 For Sheol does not thank you,
and death does not praise you;
those who go down to the pit
cannot hope for your faithfulness.
19 The living, the living, he shall thank you,
as I do this day;
the father to the children
shall make known your faithfulness.
20 Yahweh will save me;
we will play my songs on stringed instruments
all the days of our lives
in Yahweh's house.[m]
21 Now Isaiah had said, "Let them take a cake of figs, and rub it on the boil, that he may recover."[n] 22 And Hezekiah had said, "What is the sign that I shall go up to the house of Yahweh?"

Notes

- a (38:1) Compare 2 Kings 20:1–11; 2 Chronicles 32:24. The illness came before the Assyrian invasion was ended (verse 6), probably about 701 BC.

- b (38:6) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “for my own sake and for the sake of David my servant,” as in 2 Kings 20:6.
- c (38:8) Hebrew ma‘aloth, “steps” or “degrees,” perhaps a stairway used as a sundial. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “the steps of the upper chamber of Ahaz” (compare 2 Kings 23:12).
- d (38:9) Verses 9–20 are not found in 2 Kings. “A writing,” Hebrew mikhtav; some read miktam, a term in psalm titles (Psalm 16; 56–60).
- e (38:10) Or “In the noontide of my days.” Sheol, the realm of the dead.
- f (38:11) Yah, a short form of Yahweh; the Hebrew repeats it, “Yah, Yah,” but the Great Isaiah Scroll has it once. “The world” follows a few Hebrew manuscripts (heled); the standard Hebrew text reads hadel, “cessation,” that is, the place where all things cease.
- g (38:12) Or “he cuts me off from the thrum,” the threads left on the loom.
- h (38:13) Or “I cried out until morning.”
- i (38:14) Hebrew ‘arevni, “be surety for me,” stand pledge for my debt.
- j (38:15) Or “I shall walk humbly.” The Hebrew of verses 15–16 is uncertain.
- k (38:16) Or “by these things” refers to God’s words and deeds.
- l (38:17) Or “it was for peace.”
- m (38:20) The Great Isaiah Scroll repeats here, in a longer form, words from verse 19, perhaps by a copyist’s error.
- n (38:21) Verses 21–22 stand earlier in 2 Kings 20:7–8. In the Great Isaiah Scroll they are written by a later hand in the space after verse 20 and in the margin, which suggests the first copyist’s text lacked them. A cake of figs was used as a poultice.

Chapter 39

1 At that time Merodach-baladan the son of Baladan, king of Babylon,
sent letters and a present to Hezekiah; for he had heard that he had
been sick and had recovered.[a] 2 And Hezekiah was glad because of
them, and let them see his house of costly things, the silver and
the gold and the spices and the precious oil, and all his house of
weapons, and whatever was to be found among his treasures. There
was nothing in his house, nor in all his dominion, that Hezekiah left
unshown to them.[b]
3 Then Isaiah the prophet came to King Hezekiah, and said to him,
“What did these men say? And from where did they come to you?”
And Hezekiah said, “From a far country they have come to me, from
Babylon.” 4 Isaiah asked, “What did these men look at in your palace?”
Hezekiah said, “Everything in my palace was shown to them; none
of my treasures remained hidden from them.” 5 Then Isaiah said to

Hezekiah, “Hear the word of Yahweh of Armies: 6 Behold, days are coming when all that is in your house, and that which your fathers have laid up until this day, shall be carried to Babylon; nothing shall be left, says Yahweh. 7 And some of your sons, who shall come forth from you, whom you shall beget, shall be taken away; and they shall be eunuchs in the palace of the king of Babylon.”[c] 8 Then Hezekiah said to Isaiah, “Good is the word of Yahweh which you have spoken.” For he said to himself, “Surely in my days there shall be peace and truth.”[d]

Notes

- a (39:1) Compare 2 Kings 20:12–19. Merodach-baladan, Akkadian Marduk-apla-iddina, “Marduk has given an heir,” a Chaldean chief who held Babylon against Assyria in 721–710 BC and briefly in 703 BC; he was seeking allies. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “and he had lived” for “and had recovered.”
- b (39:2) 2 Kings 20:13 reads “listened to them.”
- c (39:7) Compare Daniel 1:3–7.
- d (39:8) Or “peace and stability.”

Chapter 40

1 “Comfort, comfort my people,”
says your God.[a]
2 “Speak to the heart of Jerusalem,
and call out to her
that her service of war is fulfilled,
that her iniquity is paid off,
that she has received from the hand of Yahweh
double for all her sins.”[b]
3 A voice calls out,
“In the wilderness make ready the way of Yahweh;
make straight in the desert
a highway for our God.[c]
4 Every valley shall be lifted up,
and every mountain and hill be brought low;
the crooked ground shall become level,
and the rugged places a plain.[d]

5 And the glory of Yahweh shall be revealed,
and all flesh shall see it together;
for the mouth of Yahweh has spoken."[e]
6 A voice says, "Cry out!"
And one said, "What shall I cry?"
"All flesh is grass,
and all its steadfast love is like the flower of the field.[f]
7 The grass dries up, the flower withers,
when the breath of Yahweh blows upon it;
surely the people are grass.[g]
8 The grass dries up, the flower withers,
but the word of our God shall stand forever."[h]
9 Get up onto a high mountain,
O Zion, bearer of good news;
raise your voice with might,
O Jerusalem, bearer of good news;
raise it, do not be afraid;
say to the cities of Judah,
"Here is your God!"[i]
10 Behold, the Lord Yahweh comes with strength,
and his arm rules for him;
behold, his wages are with him,
and his recompense goes before him.[j]
11 Like a shepherd he shall pasture his flock;
in his arm he shall gather the lambs,
and carry them in his bosom,
and gently lead those that give suck.
12 Who has measured the waters in the hollow of his hand,
and marked off the heavens with the span,
and held the dust of the earth in a measure,
and weighed the mountains in a scale
and the hills in a balance?[k]
13 Who has measured the Spirit of Yahweh,
or as his counselor has instructed him?[l]

14 With whom did he consult, and who gave him understanding,
and taught him in the path of justice,
and taught him knowledge,
and made known to him the way of discernment?
15 Behold, the nations are as a drop from a bucket,
and are reckoned as the fine dust on the scales;
behold, he takes up the coastlands like powder.[m]
16 Lebanon would not suffice for fuel,
nor its beasts suffice for a burnt offering.
17 All the nations are as nothing before him;
they are counted by him as less than nothing and emptiness.[n]
18 To whom then will you compare God,
or what likeness will you set beside him?
19 An idol! A craftsman molds it,
a goldsmith covers it with gold
and makes silver chains for it.[o]
20 One who is too poor to give that kind of offering
chooses a tree that will not rot;
he hunts for a talented craftsman
to set up an idol that will not topple.[p]
21 Have you not known? Have you not heard?
Was it not declared to you from the first?
Have you not discerned it since the earth was founded?
22 It is he who sits above the circle of the earth,
and its inhabitants are as grasshoppers;
who stretches out the heavens as a fine cloth,
and spreads them like a tent to dwell in;[q]
23 who brings rulers to nothing,
and makes the judges of the earth as emptiness.[r]
24 They are barely planted, barely sown,
their stems have barely put down roots in the ground,
when he blows on them and they wither,
and a whirlwind sweeps them away like straw.
25 "To whom then will you compare me,
that I should be his equal?" says the Holy One.

[26] Raise your eyes to the height and look:
who has made these things?
It is he who leads forth their army by count,
and summons each of them by name;
through the abundance of his strength, and the might of his power,
not one of them fails to appear.[s]
[27] Jacob, why do you say,
Israel, why do you speak so:
"My way is hidden from Yahweh,
and my right is passed over by my God"?
[28] Have you not known? Have you not heard?
Yahweh is God of the ages,
who created the far ends of the earth.
He grows neither faint nor weary;
there is no searching out of his understanding.
[29] He gives strength to the weary,
and increases the power of those who have none.[t]
[30] Even youths shall faint and be weary,
and young men shall stumble and fall;
[31] but those who wait for Yahweh shall renew their strength;
they shall mount up with wings as eagles;
they shall run and not be weary;
they shall walk and not faint.[u]

Notes

- a (40:1) Chapters 40–66 address the exiles in Babylon and their return; many scholars assign them to a later prophet or prophets in the tradition of Isaiah (often called Second and Third Isaiah, chapters 40–55 and 56–66), while others hold to the unity of the book. The two halves share many themes, such as "the Holy One of Israel." The Septuagint adds "O priests" in verse 2.
- b (40:2) Or "her hard service." Hebrew tsava', "army," "warfare," here forced service. "Double" may mean full payment, a full equivalent.
- c (40:3) Or "A voice calls out in the wilderness, 'Make ready the way of Yahweh.'" The Septuagint, followed by Matthew 3:3, Mark 1:3, Luke 3:4, and John 1:23, links "in the wilderness" with the voice.
- d (40:4) Luke 3:5 quotes verses 4–5 from the Septuagint.
- e (40:5) The Septuagint adds "the salvation of God," as quoted in Luke 3:6.

- f (40:6) “One said”: the Great Isaiah Scroll and the Septuagint read “and I said,” making the prophet the speaker. Hebrew hesed, “steadfast love,” “faithfulness”; the Septuagint has “glory,” as quoted in 1 Peter 1:24.
- g (40:7) Or “the wind of Yahweh.” In the Great Isaiah Scroll the words from “when the breath” to the end of verse 8 are partly written by a later hand above the line and in the margin; the first copyist’s eye seems to have skipped from the first “the flower withers” to the second. The Septuagint lacks verse 7 and the first line of verse 8.
- h (40:8) 1 Peter 1:24–25 quotes verses 6–8.
- i (40:9) Or “O bearer of good news to Zion … O bearer of good news to Jerusalem.” The Hebrew participle is feminine.
- j (40:10) Hebrew Adonai Yahweh. Compare Revelation 22:12.
- k (40:12) The span is about 9 inches (about 23 centimeters), from thumb to little finger. “A measure,” Hebrew shalish, “a third,” perhaps a third of an ephah. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “the waters of the sea.”
- l (40:13) Or “Who has directed.” The Septuagint reads “Who has known the mind of the Lord?” as quoted in Romans 11:34 and 1 Corinthians 2:16.
- m (40:15) Or “like fine dust.”
- n (40:17) Hebrew tohu, the word for the formless earth in Genesis 1:2.
- o (40:19) The Hebrew of verses 19–20 is uncertain.
- p (40:20) Hebrew mesukkan terumah; the meaning is unclear. Some take it as a kind of wood, “mulberry” or “sissoo.”
- q (40:22) Hebrew hug, “circle,” the vault or horizon of the earth.
- r (40:23) Hebrew tohu.
- s (40:26) The “host” are the stars, seen as an army. The Great Isaiah Scroll and some other witnesses read “and not one.”
- t (40:29) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “It is he who gives.”
- u (40:31) Or “as the eagle.” The Hebrew nesher may also mean the griffon vulture.

Chapter 41

1 “Be quiet before me, you coastlands;
let the nations gain new strength;
let them approach and then speak;
let us meet together for the trial.[a]
2 Who stirred up one from the east,
whom righteousness calls to its feet?
He gives up nations before him,
and he makes him trample kings;
his sword turns them to dust,
his bow to stubble blown away.[b]

3 He pursues them and passes on in safety,
by a path his feet have not traveled.[c]
4 Who has worked and done it,
calling the generations from the beginning?
I, Yahweh, the first,
and with the last, I am he."[d]
5 The coastlands saw it and feared;
the far ends of the earth trembled;
they drew close and came.[e]
6 Every man gives help to his fellow,
and to his brother he says, "Take courage!"
7 The craftsman urges on the goldsmith,
and the one who smooths with a hammer encourages the one who pounds on the anvil,
saying of the welding, "It is good";
then he fixes the idol with nails so that it will not fall over.
8 But you, Israel, my servant,
Jacob, whom I have chosen,
the offspring of Abraham, my friend;[f]
9 you whom I took hold of from the ends of the earth,
and called from its farthest corners,
and said to you, "You are my servant;
I have chosen you, and not cast you off";
10 do not fear, for I am with you;
do not look about in dread, for I am your God;
I will make you strong, yes, I will help you;
yes, I will hold you up with my righteous right hand.[g]
11 Look, all who are angry with you
will be ashamed and humiliated;
those who oppose you
will be as nothing and will perish.[h]
12 You will look for those who fight you
but will not find them;
those who wage war against you
will be as nothing, as less than nothing.

13 For I am Yahweh your God,
who grasps your right hand,
who says to you, “Fear not;
I am your helper.”
14 Do not fear, you worm Jacob,
you men of Israel!
I will help you, declares Yahweh;
your Redeemer is the Holy One of Israel.[i]
15 Behold, I have made you a threshing sledge,
sharp and new, with many edges;
you shall tread down the mountains and beat them fine,
and shall make the hills as chaff;[j]
16 you shall fan them, and the wind shall bear them off,
and the whirlwind shall disperse them;
but you shall be glad in Yahweh;
in the Holy One of Israel you shall glory.
17 The poor and the needy seek water, and there is none,
and their tongue is parched with thirst;
I, Yahweh, will answer them;
I, the God of Israel, will not forsake them.
18 I will open rivers on the bare heights,
and fountains in the midst of the valleys;
I will make the wilderness a pool of water,
and the dry land springs of water.
19 I will plant cedars in the wilderness,
along with acacias, myrtles and olive trees;
I will place junipers in the desert,
with planes and pines alongside them;[k]
20 that they may see and know,
and consider and understand together,
that the hand of Yahweh has done this,
the Holy One of Israel has created it.
21 Set forth your case, says Yahweh;
bring forward your strong arguments, says the King of Jacob.

22 Let them bring in their idols and tell us
what will happen.
What were the earlier events? Tell us,
so we can consider them
and learn how they ended;
or announce to us what is coming.[l]
23 Tell the things that are to come hereafter,
that we may know that you are gods;
yes, do good or do evil,
that we may be dismayed and see it together.[m]
24 See, you are of nothing,
and your doing is of naught;
whoever chooses you is detestable.[n]
25 I have stirred up one from the north, and he has come,
from the rising of the sun, one who shall call on my name;
and he shall come upon rulers as on mortar,
as the potter treads clay.[o]
26 Who told it from the start, so that we could know it,
or from times before, so that we could say, "He is in the right"?
Not one of you foretold it, not one announced it;
not one has heard a word from you.
27 I first said to Zion, "Behold, here they are!"
and to Jerusalem I give a bearer of good news.[p]
28 I look, but there is no one;
among these idols there is no adviser
who can give an answer when I ask.
29 Look, they are all a sham;
their works amount to nothing;
their cast images are wind and chaos.[q]

Notes

- a (41:1) "Coastlands," or "islands," the far lands of the Mediterranean.
- b (41:2) Cyrus II of Persia (verse 25; 44:28; 45:1), who conquered Babylon in 539 BC. Or "whom he calls in righteousness to his service."

- c (41:3) Or “by a path he had not gone with his feet,” that is, so swiftly that his feet hardly touch the road. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “they did not understand” for “he goes.”
- d (41:4) Compare 44:6; 48:12; Revelation 1:8, 17; 22:13.
- e (41:5) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “together” (yahdu) for “tremble” (yeheradu).
- f (41:8) Compare 2 Chronicles 20:7; James 2:23. Chapters 41–53 often speak of Yahweh’s “servant”: sometimes Israel, sometimes a figure with a mission to Israel (see the note on 42:1).
- g (41:10) Or “my victorious right hand.” Hebrew tsedeq, “righteousness,” often means vindication or victory in these chapters.
- h (41:11) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks “shall be as nothing and shall perish” and, in verse 12, “You shall seek … not find them,” probably because a copyist’s eye skipped between similar words.
- i (41:14) “Redeemer,” Hebrew go’el, the next of kin who buys back a relative’s land or freedom (Leviticus 25:25, 48; Ruth 4:4–6), and who avenges his blood. The phrase first occurs here and is frequent in chapters 41–63.
- j (41:15) A heavy board studded underneath with sharp stones or iron, dragged over grain to thresh it.
- k (41:19) The identification of several of these trees is uncertain. Hebrew ʻets shemen, “oil tree,” perhaps the olive or the oleaster.
- l (41:22) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “or the latter things.”
- m (41:23) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “that we may hear” for “that we may be dismayed and see.”
- n (41:24) Hebrew me’apa’, a rare word; many read me’efes, “of nothing” (compare 40:17). The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the word.
- o (41:25) Cyrus came from the east (verse 2), and also from the north, after conquering Media and Lydia.
- p (41:27) The Hebrew is obscure; literally “First to Zion, Behold, behold them.” The Great Isaiah Scroll differs slightly.
- q (41:29) Hebrew ʻawen, “trouble,” “iniquity,” “nothing”; the Great Isaiah Scroll and a few Hebrew manuscripts read ʻayin, “nothing.” “Emptiness,” Hebrew tohu.

Chapter 42

1 Behold my servant, whom I uphold,
my chosen, in whom my soul delights;
I have put my Spirit upon him;
he shall bring forth justice to the nations.[a]
2 He shall not cry out nor lift up his voice,
nor make it heard in the street;

3 a bruised reed he shall not break,
and a dimly burning wick he shall not snuff out;
in faithfulness he shall bring forth justice.[b]
4 He will not falter or be broken
until he sets justice in place on the earth;
the distant coastlands wait for his instruction.[c]
5 Thus says God, Yahweh,
the Creator of the heavens, who stretched them forth,
who beat out the earth and all that springs from it,
who grants breath to the people on it,
and spirit to those who walk in it:[d]
6 I am Yahweh; I have called you in righteousness;
I will grasp you by the hand and guard you;
and I will make you a covenant for the people,
a light to the nations,[e]
7 to open blind eyes,
to lead out the captive from the dungeon,
and those who sit in darkness from the house of confinement.
8 I am Yahweh; this is my name;
and my glory I will not yield to another,
nor my praise to graven images.
9 Look, the earlier events have happened,
and I announce new ones;
before they begin to appear,
I tell you about them.
10 Sing to Yahweh a new song,
his praise from the end of the earth,
you who go down to the sea, and all that fills it,
the coastlands and those who dwell in them.[f]
11 Let the wilderness and its towns lift up their voice,
the villages where Kedar dwells;
let the inhabitants of Sela sing for joy,
let them shout from the top of the mountains.[g]
12 Let them give glory to Yahweh,
and declare his praise in the coastlands.

13 Yahweh marches out like a warrior;
like a soldier he rouses his zeal;
he shouts, he lets out a battle cry;
he proves himself stronger than his enemies.[h]
14 Long have I been silent;
I have been still and held myself back;
now like a woman giving birth I will groan;
I will pant and gasp at once.
15 I will lay mountains and hills waste
and dry up everything that grows on them;
I will change rivers into islands
and dry up the pools.[i]
16 And I will bring the blind
by a road unknown to them;
by tracks they have never known I will lead them;
I will turn darkness before them into light,
and rough ways into a plain.
These things I will do for them,
and I will not leave them.
17 They shall be turned back and utterly ashamed,
who trust in carved idols,
who say to molten images,
"You are our gods."
18 Hear, you deaf;
and look, you blind, that you may see!
19 Who is blind but my servant,
or deaf as my messenger whom I send?
Who is blind as the one in covenant with me,
or blind as the servant of Yahweh?[j]
20 You see many things, but you do not observe;
his ears are open, but he does not hear.[k]
21 Yahweh delighted, for his justice' sake,
to make his teaching great and to give it honor.[l]
22 But this is a people looted and plundered,
all of them trapped in pits

and concealed in dungeons;
they have become loot with no one to save them,
plunder with no one saying, “Give it back!”[m]
23 Which of you will lend an ear to this,
will heed and hear it for days to come?
24 Who handed Jacob over to the plunderer
and Israel to the looters?
Was it not Yahweh, the one we sinned against,
whose ways they refused to follow
and whose instruction they did not obey?[n]
25 So he poured out on Israel his burning anger
and the violence of war;
it set him on fire all around, yet he did not understand;
it burned him, yet he took none of it to heart.[o]

Notes

- a (42:1) The first of four passages often called the “Servant Songs” (42:1–4 or 1–9; 49:1–6; 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12). The Septuagint reads “Jacob my servant … Israel my chosen.” Matthew 12:18–21 quotes verses 1–4 of Jesus; compare Matthew 3:17; 17:5.
- b (42:3) Or “according to truth.” The Septuagint reads “he shall bring forth judgment to truth”; Matthew 12:20 has “until he brings justice to victory.”
- c (42:4) The verbs echo verse 3: he will not burn dim, nor be bruised. Matthew 12:21, following the Septuagint, reads “and in his name the nations will hope.”
- d (42:5) Hebrew ha’el Yahweh; the Great Isaiah Scroll appears to read ha’el ha’elohim, “the God, God” (the letter after the first word is uncertain).
- e (42:6) Or “a covenant people,” Hebrew berith ‘am, an obscure phrase. Compare 49:6, 8; Luke 2:32; Acts 13:47.
- f (42:10) Some propose “let the sea roar” for “you who go down to the sea,” compare Psalm 96:11; 98:7.
- g (42:11) Kedar, an Arab tribe of the desert (21:16). Sela, “rock,” perhaps the Edomite stronghold (2 Kings 14:7), or any rocky height.
- h (42:13) Or “he triumphs over his enemies.”
- i (42:15) Some read “dry land” (tsiyyoth) for “coastlands” (iyyim).
- j (42:19) Hebrew meshullam, “one at peace,” “one made whole,” “one dedicated,” or “one repaid”; its sense here is uncertain.
- k (42:20) The Hebrew text has “You have seen” (written form) or “Seeing” (read form). The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “You have seen many things … they have opened their ears.”
- l (42:21) Or “instruction,” Hebrew torah; also in verse 24.
- m (42:22) Or “they are all snared by young men,” reading bahurim.

- n (42:24) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “to plunder” (limshussah, the word of the Hebrew’s written form) without a second “to the spoiler.” The shift from “we” to “they” is in the Hebrew.
- o (42:25) Or “the fierceness of his wrath.”

Chapter 43

1 But now thus says Yahweh,
your Creator, O Jacob,
and your Former, O Israel:
Be not afraid, for I have bought you back;
I have called you by name; you belong to me.
2 When you pass through the waters, I will be with you;
when you cross rivers, they will not wash over you;
when you walk through fire, you will not be burned,
and the flames will not scorch you.
3 For I, Yahweh, am your God,
Israel’s Holy One, the one who saves you;
Egypt I have given as the price of your release,
Cush and Seba in exchange for you.[a]
4 Because you are precious in my eyes,
honored, and I love you,
I give men in exchange for you,
and peoples for your life.
5 Do not be afraid, for I am with you;
I will bring your descendants from the east
and gather you from the west.
6 I will say to the north, “Give up!”
and to the south, “Do not keep back!
Bring my sons from afar,
and my daughters from the end of the earth,
7 every one who is called by my name,
whom I created for my glory,
whom I formed, yes, whom I made.”
8 Lead out the blind people that have eyes,
and the deaf that have ears!

9 Let all the nations come together
and the peoples gather.
Which of them can announce this
or let us hear about earlier events?
10 You are my witnesses, declares Yahweh,
and the servant I chose,
so that you may know me, trust me
and understand that I am the same one.
Before me no god was made,
and after me there will be none.[b]
11 I, I am Yahweh,
and apart from me there is no savior.
12 I was the one who announced, rescued and made it known,
when there was no foreign god among you;
you are my witnesses, declares Yahweh, and I am God.
13 Even from this day on I am he,
and from my hand no one rescues;
when I act, who shall reverse it?[c]
14 Thus says Yahweh,
your Redeemer, Israel's Holy One:
Because of you I have sent to Babylon,
and I will make all of them flee,
and the Chaldeans in the ships of their shouting.[d]
15 I am Yahweh, your Holy One,
the Creator of Israel, your King.
16 This is what Yahweh says,
he who opens a road through the sea
and a path through raging waters,
17 who brings forth chariot and horse,
army and warrior together;
they lie down, they shall not rise;
they are snuffed out, quenched like a wick:
18 Do not remember the former things,
nor ponder the things of old.

19 See, I am about to do something new;
even now it sprouts; will you not know it?
I will make a way in the wilderness,
rivers in the desert.[e]
20 The wild beasts shall honor me,
the jackals and the ostriches,
for I give waters in the wilderness,
rivers in the desert,
to give drink to my chosen people,
21 the people I formed for myself
so they would tell of my praise.
22 Yet you have not called upon me, O Jacob;
but you have grown weary of me, O Israel.
23 You have not brought me the sheep of your burnt offerings,
nor honored me with your sacrifices;
I have not made you serve with offerings,
nor wearied you with frankincense.[f]
24 You have not bought me sweet cane with silver,
nor filled me with the fat of your sacrifices;
but you have made me serve with your sins;
you have wearied me with your iniquities.[g]
25 I, I myself, am the one
who blots out your rebellion for my own sake,
and I will not recall your sins.[h]
26 Remind me; let us go to judgment together;
set forth your case, that you may be proved right.
27 Your first father sinned,
and your spokesmen transgressed against me.[i]
28 Therefore I will profane the princes of the sanctuary,
and give Jacob over to the ban,
and Israel to reviling.[j]

Notes

- a (43:3) Cush, the upper Nile region (Nubia, in modern Sudan). Seba, probably a land near Cush (Genesis 10:7). In the Great Isaiah Scroll "your Redeemer" is written above the line in place of "your Savior."

- b (43:10) Compare John 8:24, 28; 13:19, where Jesus uses "I am he."
- c (43:13) Or "From eternity I am he" or "Since the day was."
- d (43:14) The Hebrew of the last line is uncertain. Another reading is "I will smash all the bolts, and the Chaldeans' cries will become mourning."
- e (43:19) Compare 2 Corinthians 5:17; Revelation 21:5.
- f (43:23) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "and you have not done."
- g (43:24) Sweet cane, an aromatic reed used in the holy anointing oil (Exodus 30:23).
- h (43:25) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "any more."
- i (43:27) The "first father" may be Jacob (Hosea 12:2–4). "Spokesmen," Hebrew melitsim, "interpreters," "mediators."
- j (43:28) Hebrew herem, the ban of total destruction or devotion to God (Joshua 6:17).

Chapter 44

1 But now hear, O Jacob my servant,
and Israel, whom I have chosen.
2 Thus says Yahweh, your Maker,
who shaped you in the womb, who will be your help:
Be not afraid, Jacob, my servant,
and you, Jeshurun, my chosen one.[a]
3 For I will pour water on the thirsty land,
and streams on the dry ground;
I will pour my Spirit upon your seed,
and my blessing on your offspring.
4 And they shall shoot up like grass amid the waters,
as poplars beside the channels of water.[b]
5 One shall say, "I am Yahweh's,"
and another shall call himself by the name of Jacob,
and another shall write on his hand, "Yahweh's,"
and take as his surname the name of Israel.[c]
6 This is what Yahweh, Israel's King and Redeemer, Yahweh of Armies, says:
I am the first and I am the last;
there is no God except me.[d]
7 Who is like me? Let him announce it,
lay out his case before me,
since I set up my ancient people;

let them declare what is coming
and what will take place.[e]
8 Do not tremble, nor be afraid;
have I not told you long since and declared it?
And you are my witnesses!
Is there a God apart from me?
There is no Rock; I know of none.[f]
9 All who fashion carved idols are emptiness,
and the things they take pleasure in do not profit;
their witnesses neither see nor know,
so that they shall be put to shame.[g]
10 Who forms a god or casts an image
that profits nothing?
11 Look, all his associates will be put to shame,
and the craftsmen are merely human beings;
let them all assemble and take their stand;
they will be terrified and humiliated together.
12 The smith with his tool for iron
labors at it among the embers;
with hammers he forms it,
and toils at it with his mighty arm;
yes, he is hungry, and his strength is gone;
he drinks no water and grows faint.
13 The woodworker stretches a line;
he marks it out with a stylus;
he shapes it with planes
and marks it with the compass;
he makes it after the figure of a man,
with the beauty of a human being,
to dwell in a house.[h]
14 He cuts down cedars for himself,
or takes a holm oak or a terebinth,
and lets it grow sturdy for himself in the woodland;
he sets out a laurel, and the shower nourishes it.[i]

15 Then it serves a man for burning;
he takes some of it and gets warm;
yes, he lights it and bakes his loaves;
yes, he fashions a god and bows to it;
he shapes a graven image and falls down before it.
16 Part of it he burns in the flames;
upon that part he cooks meat to eat;
he roasts a roast and is satisfied;
also he warms himself and says,
"Aha, I am warm, I have seen the blaze!"
17 From the leftover wood he makes a god, his idol;
he kneels to it and worships it;
he prays to it and says,
"Rescue me, because you are my god!"
18 Knowledge they lack, and discernment they lack;
for their eyes are plastered shut from seeing,
and their hearts from perceiving.[j]
19 No one calls it to mind,
nor is there knowledge or insight to say,
"Part of it I have burned in the flames;
yes, and on its embers I baked loaves;
I have roasted meat and eaten it;
and shall I make the rest of it an abomination?
Shall I bow down before a block of wood?"[k]
20 He shepherds ashes; a cheated heart has turned him aside;
he cannot rescue his own soul, nor say,
"Is there not a lie in my right hand?"[l]
21 Remember these things, O Jacob,
and Israel, for you are my servant;
I formed you, you are a servant to me;
O Israel, you shall not be forgotten by me.[m]
22 I have swept away your rebellion like a dense cloud
and your sins like morning mist;
come back to me, for I have ransomed you.

23 Sing for joy, heavens, because Yahweh has acted;
shout, you depths of the earth;
burst into song, you mountains,
you forest and every tree in it!
For Yahweh has ransomed Jacob
and displays his glory in Israel.[n]
24 Thus says Yahweh, your Redeemer,
who formed you from the womb:
I am Yahweh, who makes all things,
who by myself spread the heavens wide,
who beat out the land. Who was with me?[o]
25 He frustrates the signs of the babblers,
and makes fools of diviners;
he turns the wise back,
and makes their knowledge foolish;[p]
26 who makes his servant's word come true
and carries out the plans of his messengers;
who says about Jerusalem, "People will live in her,"
and about the towns of Judah, "They will be rebuilt,
and I will restore their ruins";[q]
27 who says to the ocean depth, "Become dry,
and your streams I will parch";[r]
28 who says about Cyrus, "He is my shepherd,
and he will accomplish everything I want";
who says about Jerusalem, "She will be rebuilt,"
and about the temple, "Your foundation will be laid."[s]

Notes

- a (44:2) Jeshurun, a poetic name for Israel, probably "upright one" (from yashar, "upright"); compare Deuteronomy 32:15; 33:5, 26.
- b (44:4) "Amid the waters" follows the Septuagint ("as grass between brooks"); the standard Hebrew text reads "among the grass."
- c (44:5) Or "write on his hand, 'Belonging to Yahweh,'" as a mark of ownership (compare Ezekiel 9:4; Revelation 7:3).
- d (44:6) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Yahweh of Armies is his name." Compare 41:4; 48:12; Revelation 1:17; 22:13.

- e (44:7) The Hebrew of the second half of the verse is uncertain; some emend it to "Who declared long ago what is coming? Let them tell us what lies ahead."
- f (44:8) Compare Deuteronomy 32:4, 31; 1 Samuel 2:2.
- g (44:9) Hebrew tohu, "emptiness."
- h (44:13) Or "to sit in a shrine."
- i (44:14) The identification of these trees is uncertain. "Laurel," Hebrew oren, perhaps a pine or ash.
- j (44:18) Or "their eyes are smeared over."
- k (44:19) Hebrew tow'evah, "abomination," a term for an idol.
- l (44:20) The Hebrew may also mean "you must not forget me."
- m (44:21) Or "you shall not forget me," following the Septuagint and the Great Isaiah Scroll differs slightly.
- n (44:23) Or "and glorifies himself in Israel."
- o (44:24) "Who was with me?" follows the written Hebrew text (mi 'itti), which the Great Isaiah Scroll shares; the read form (me'itti) means "by myself."
- p (44:25) Or "the boasters." Hebrew baddim, perhaps "empty talkers," a term for false prophets.
- q (44:26) "His servant" may be the prophet. Some read "his servants" (compare the Septuagint).
- r (44:27) Perhaps an allusion to the drying of the Red Sea (51:10), or to Babylon's river.
- s (44:28) Cyrus II ("the Great"), founder of the Persian Empire, who conquered Babylon in 539 BC and in 538 BC allowed the Jews to return and rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:1–4). Persian Kurush; the meaning of the name is uncertain. He is named here and in 45:1.

Chapter 45

1 Thus says Yahweh to his anointed,
to Cyrus, whose right hand I have grasped,
to subdue nations before him,
and to loosen the belts of kings,
to open doors before him,
so that gates shall not be shut:[a]
2 I will go before you
and level the mountains;
doors of bronze I will shatter,
and cut through bars of iron.[b]
3 And I will give you the treasures of darkness,
and riches stored in secret places,

that you may know that I am Yahweh,
the God of Israel, who calls you by your name.
4 For the sake of my servant Jacob,
my chosen Israel,
I call you by name;
I give you an honorary title, though you do not know me.[c]
5 I am Yahweh, and there is no other;
there is no God but me;
I equip you, though you do not know me,
6 that men may know from the rising of the sun,
and from its setting, that there is none besides me;
I am Yahweh, and there is no other.
7 I form light and create darkness;
I make peace and create calamity;
I am Yahweh, who does all these things.[d]
8 Heavens, send down dew from above,
and let the skies pour out righteousness;
let the earth open up so salvation may sprout,
and let righteousness grow along with it;
I, Yahweh, have created it.[e]
9 Woe to him who contends with his Maker,
a potsherd among the potsherds of the ground!
Shall the clay say to him who shapes it, "What are you making?"
or your handiwork, "He has no hands"?[f]
10 How terrible for one who says to his father, "What are you fathering?"
or to his mother, "What are you giving birth to?"
11 Thus says Yahweh,
the Holy One of Israel, and its Maker:
Ask me of things to come;
concerning my sons and the work of my hands
will you command me?[g]
12 I made the earth,
and created man upon it;

my hands spread out the skies,
and all their host I set in command.
13 I have roused him up in righteousness,
and I will make straight all his ways;
he shall build my city
and set my exiles free,
not for a price nor for a bribe,
says Yahweh of Armies.
14 Thus says Yahweh:
The toil of Egypt and the gain of Cush,
and the Sabeans, men of great stature,
shall come over to you and be yours;
they shall walk behind you;
in chains they shall come over,
and bow down to you;
they shall pray to you:
"Surely God is in you, and there is no other,
no god besides."[h]
15 Surely you are a God who keeps himself hidden,
the God of Israel, who saves.[i]
16 They are put to shame and disgraced, all of them;
the makers of idols go off in confusion together.
17 But Israel is saved by Yahweh
with a salvation for the ages;
you shall not be put to shame nor disgraced
to the ages of eternity.
18 For this is what Yahweh says,
the creator of the heavens (he is God!),
the maker of the earth who set it firm
(he did not create it to be empty,
but formed it for people to live in):
I am Yahweh, and there is no other.[j]
19 I did not speak in secret,
in some place of a land of darkness;
I did not say to the seed of Jacob,

"Seek me in emptiness."
I, Yahweh, speak what is right;
I declare what is upright.[k]
20 Come together and approach, all you who survived among the nations!
Those who haul their wooden idols around
and keep praying to a god that cannot rescue
do not know what they are doing.
21 Declare and bring forward your case;
yes, let them take counsel together!
Who made this heard from ancient times?
Who told it from back then?
Is it not I, Yahweh?
And there is no other god apart from me,
a righteous God and a Savior;
there is none besides me.
22 Turn to me and be saved,
all the ends of the earth!
For I am God, and there is no other.
23 I have taken an oath by my own self;
a word of righteousness has gone out of my mouth,
and it shall not return:
"To me every knee shall bow,
every tongue shall swear."[l]
24 "In Yahweh alone," one shall say of me,
"is victory and might";
to him they shall come, and they shall be shamed,
all who were incensed against him.[m]
25 In Yahweh all the seed of Israel
shall be justified and shall glory.

Notes

- a (45:1) "His anointed," Hebrew meshiho, the only place in the Hebrew Bible where a foreign king is called Yahweh's anointed (compare the kings of Israel, 1 Samuel 24:6; Psalm 2:2). From mashiah, "anointed one," comes the word Messiah. "Loosen the belts," literally "open the loins," that is, disarm.

- b (45:2) "The mountains" follows the Great Isaiah Scroll (hararim) and the Septuagint; the standard Hebrew text has hadurim, an obscure word perhaps meaning "swellings" or "rough places."
- c (45:4) Or "surname you."
- d (45:7) Hebrew ra', "evil," here "calamity" or "disaster," in contrast with shalom, "peace," "well-being."
- e (45:8) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Shout, O heavens ... who says to the earth, 'Let salvation blossom'" and lacks the last line.
- f (45:9) The Hebrew text is difficult. The Great Isaiah Scroll and some other witnesses differ. Compare Jeremiah 18:6; Romans 9:20–21.
- g (45:11) Or "Will you question me about my children, and command me about the work of my hands?" The Hebrew word order is ambiguous.
- h (45:14) Cush, see the note on 43:3. The Sabeans, see 43:3 (Seba).
- i (45:15) Or "Truly, with you God hides himself."
- j (45:18) Hebrew tohu (see Genesis 1:2).
- k (45:19) Hebrew tohu.
- l (45:23) Compare Romans 14:11; Philippians 2:10–11.
- m (45:24) The Hebrew is uncertain; literally "Only in Yahweh, he said to me, are righteousness and strength."

Chapter 46

1 Bel has bowed down, Nebo stoops;
their idols are loaded on beasts and cattle;
the things you once carried in procession
are now a load, a burden on weary animals.[a]
2 They stoop, they bow down together;
they could not rescue the burden,
but they themselves have gone into captivity.[b]
3 Listen to me, house of Jacob,
and all who remain of the house of Israel,
you whom I have carried since your birth,
held since you were in the womb:
4 until you are old I am the same,
and until your hair turns gray I will carry you.
I made you, and I will hold you up;
I will carry you and rescue you.[c]
5 To whom will you liken me and make me equal,
and compare me, that we may be alike?

6 Those who lavish gold from the purse,
and weigh out silver on the scale,
pay a smith to work it into a god;
before it they fall prostrate and adore it.
7 They hoist it onto a shoulder and carry it;
they put it down in its spot, and there it stays;
it never moves from its place.
Even if someone calls out to it, it does not reply
or rescue him from his trouble.
8 Remember this and stand firm;
call it back to mind, you rebels.[d]
9 Remember the former things of long ago;
for I am God, and there is no other;
I am God, and there is none like me,
10 announcing the end at the start
and, long beforehand, what has not yet happened,
saying, "My plan will stand,
and I will do everything I please,"[e]
11 calling a bird of prey from the east,
the man of my counsel from a far land.
I have spoken, and I will bring it about;
I have planned it, and I will do it.[f]
12 Hearken to me, you hard of heart,
who stand far off from righteousness:
13 I bring near my righteousness; it is not far off,
and my salvation shall not linger;
I will put salvation in Zion,
for Israel my glory.[g]

Notes

- a (46:1) Bel, "lord," a title of Marduk, chief god of Babylon. Nebo (Nabu), Marduk's son, god of writing; his name forms part of Nebuchadnezzar (Nabu-kudurri-usur). Their images were carried in procession at the New Year festival; here they are carted off as plunder.
- b (46:2) Or "they could not save the load," that is, the idols could not save themselves or those carrying them.

- c (46:4) Yahweh carries his people (verses 3–4), where the idols must be carried (verses 1, 7).
- d (46:8) Hebrew hith'oshashu, an obscure word, perhaps "be men," "take heart," or "be ashamed."
- e (46:10) Or "My counsel shall stand."
- f (46:11) Cyrus; compare 41:2, 25. "His counsel" follows the written Hebrew text and the Great Isaiah Scroll; the read form has "my counsel."
- g (46:13) Or "my vindication … my deliverance."

Chapter 47

1 Go down and sit in the dust,
O virgin daughter of Babylon;
sit on the ground, without a throne,
O daughter of the Chaldeans!
For no more shall they call you
soft and delicate.[a]
2 Take the hand mill and grind meal;
put off your veil,
strip off your skirt, bare your legs,
pass through the rivers.[b]
3 Your nakedness shall be laid bare,
yes, your shame shall be seen.
I will take vengeance,
and I will spare no man.[c]
4 Our Redeemer, Yahweh of Armies is his name,
the Holy One of Israel.
5 Sit in silence, and go into darkness,
O daughter of the Chaldeans;
for no more shall they call you
the mistress of kingdoms.
6 I was angry with my people;
I profaned my inheritance,
and I gave them into your hand;
you showed them no compassion;
on the aged you made your yoke very heavy.

7 And you said, “Forever I shall be the lady,”
and these things you did not take to heart,
nor did you think on how it would end.[d]
8 So now listen to this, you pleasure-seeker
lounging in comfort,
who tells herself,
“I am the one, and no one else is;
I will never be a widow
or lose my children”:[e]
9 both of these will hit you
in an instant, on a single day:
the loss of your children and widowhood;
they will come in full force on you,
in spite of your many spells
and the great strength of your charms.
10 You felt safe in your evil;
you thought, “None can see me”;
your wisdom and your learning turned you aside,
and within yourself you said,
“I am, and besides me there is none.”[f]
11 So evil comes on you,
whose dawning you shall not know;
calamity shall fall on you,
which you cannot cover by ransom;
and devastation shall overtake you in an instant,
which you did not foresee.[g]
12 Keep on, then, with your charms,
and with the throng of your witchcrafts,
over which you have toiled since your youth;
it may be you can gain by them;
it may be you can make men tremble.[h]
13 You are worn out by your many advisers;
let them rise up, I pray, and rescue you,
the dividers of the sky, the watchers of the stars,

who month by month announce
the things that are coming on you.[i]
14 Behold, they are become like stubble;
the fire burns them;
they cannot deliver themselves
from the power of the flame.
No coal is this for warming oneself,
no fire to sit before!
15 That is what they will be to you, those you worked with,
those who did business with you from your youth;
they drift away, each in his own direction;
no one is left to save you.[j]

Notes

- a (47:1) Babylon, personified as a royal woman, is to be stripped of rank and become a slave girl.
- b (47:2) Grinding at the hand mill was the work of slaves (Exodus 11:5; Judges 16:21).
- c (47:3) The Hebrew of the last line is uncertain; literally "I will not meet a man." Some read "says our Redeemer" with verse 4.
- d (47:7) Or "their end," or "its latter end." Or "I shall be forever, a mistress forever."
- e (47:8) Compare Revelation 18:7–8.
- f (47:10) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "in your knowledge" (bedatekh) for "in your wickedness" (beraʿatekh).
- g (47:11) Or "which you will not know how to charm away." Hebrew shaharah may mean "its dawn" or "a charm against it."
- h (47:12) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks the last two lines and has "until this day" instead.
- i (47:13) "Those who divide the heavens," astrologers who mark out the sky into regions. Babylon was famous for astrology.
- j (47:15) Or "those you have dealt with."

Chapter 48

1 Listen to this, house of Jacob,
you who are called by Israel's name
and who came from Judah's line,
you who take oaths in Yahweh's name
and call on the God of Israel,
though not honestly or rightly.[a]

2 For they call themselves after the holy city,
and lean upon the God of Israel;
Yahweh of Armies is his name.
3 The former things I declared long ago;
out of my mouth they went, and I made them heard;
all at once I acted, and they took place.
4 Because I knew that you are hard,
and your neck an iron sinew,
and your forehead bronze,
5 I declared them to you from of old;
before they came about I made you hear them,
lest you should say, "It was my idol that worked them;
my graven and my molten image ordained them."
6 You have heard it; now look at all of it;
will you not admit it?
From now on I am telling you new things,
hidden things that you did not know.[b]
7 Now they are brought into being, and not of old;
and before this day you did not hear them,
lest you should say, "Behold, I knew them."
8 No, you did not hear; no, you did not know;
no, from long ago your ear was not unstopped;
for I knew how very faithlessly you would deal,
and that from the womb you were called a rebel.
9 Because of my name I hold back my wrath,
and because of my praise I rein it in toward you,
so as not to cut you down.
10 See, I have refined you, though not like silver;
I have tested you in the furnace of suffering.[c]
11 For my sake, for my own sake I act;
for how could it be profaned?
And my glory to another I will not yield.[d]
12 Listen to me, O Jacob,
and Israel, whom I called:

I am he; I am the first,
and I am also the last.[e]
13 My hand also laid the foundation of the earth,
and my right hand spread out the heavens;
when I call to them,
they stand forth together.
14 Gather, all of you, and listen!
Who among them has declared these things?
He whom Yahweh loves shall do his pleasure on Babylon,
and his arm shall be against the Chaldeans.[f]
15 I, I have spoken; yes, I have called him;
I have brought him, and he shall prosper in his way.
16 Come near to me, hear this:
from the beginning I have not spoken in secret;
from the time it came to be, I was there.
And now the Lord Yahweh has sent me, and his Spirit.[g]
17 Thus says Yahweh,
your Redeemer, the Holy One of Israel:
I am Yahweh your God,
who teaches you for your profit,
who leads you in the way you should go.[h]
18 If only you had listened to my commands!
Your peace would then have flowed like a river,
and your righteousness like the waves of the sea;
19 your descendants would have been as many as the sand,
and the children born to you as numerous as its grains;
their name would never have been erased
or wiped out from my presence.
20 Go out from Babylon, flee from the Chaldeans!
With a voice of singing declare it, make it heard;
send it forth to the end of the earth;
say, "Yahweh has redeemed his servant Jacob!"[i]
21 And they were not thirsty when he guided them through the wastelands;

water out of the rock he caused to run for them;
he cleaved the rock, and out streamed the waters.[j]
22 There is no peace, says Yahweh, for the wicked.[k]

Notes

- a (48:1) "The waters of Judah," perhaps meaning Judah as a fountain (compare Psalm 68:26). Some read "from the loins of Judah" (mimme'e).
- b (48:6) Or "I made you hear new things."
- c (48:10) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "I have tested you" (behantikha) for "I have chosen you" (behartikha), the standard Hebrew text. The Septuagint reads "I have rescued you from the furnace." This rendering follows the scroll.
- d (48:11) "It" is the divine name (compare verse 9). The Septuagint reads "because my name is profaned."
- e (48:12) Compare 41:4; 44:6; Revelation 1:17; 22:13.
- f (48:14) Or "Yahweh loves him; he shall do his pleasure." The Great Isaiah Scroll differs: "Yahweh loves me; he shall do my pleasure."
- g (48:16) Or "has sent me with his Spirit." Hebrew Adonai Yahweh. The speaker may be the prophet or the servant.
- h (48:17) Or "for your benefit."
- i (48:20) Compare Jeremiah 50:8; 51:6; Revelation 18:4. The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "send it forth."
- j (48:21) Compare Exodus 17:6; Numbers 20:11.
- k (48:22) Repeated in 57:21. This line closes the first of three sections of nine chapters each in chapters 40–66 (40–48, 49–57, 58–66).

Chapter 49

1 Listen to me, O coastlands,
and give heed, you peoples from far away!
Yahweh called me from the womb;
from my mother's body he made mention of my name.[a]
2 And he has set my mouth as a keen sword;
he has kept me hidden in the shade of his hand;
and he has made me a burnished shaft;
he has stored me away in his quiver.[b]
3 And he said to me, "You are my servant,
Israel, in whom I will show my glory."[c]
4 But I said, "I have toiled for nothing;
for emptiness and vapor I have used up my strength;

yet surely my right is with Yahweh,
and my wage with my God."[d]
5 And now Yahweh says,
he who shaped me in the womb to be his servant,
to bring Jacob back to him
and gather Israel to him,
because I am held in honor by Yahweh,
and my God has become my strength:[e]
6 he says, "It is a light thing for you to be my servant,
for raising the tribes of Jacob,
and for restoring the preserved of Israel;
and I will give you as a light to the Gentiles,
to be my salvation unto the farthest part of the earth."[f]
7 Thus says Yahweh,
the Redeemer of Israel, his Holy One,
to him whom men scorn, whom the nation loathes,
a slave of those who rule:
"Kings shall behold it and stand up,
and princes shall fall prostrate,
because of Yahweh, who is faithful,
the Holy One of Israel, who has chosen you."[g]
8 Thus says Yahweh:
In a time of favor I have answered you,
and in a day of salvation I have helped you;
I will guard you and give you as a covenant for the people,
to restore the land,
to apportion the desolate heritages,[h]
9 telling the prisoners, "Come out,"
and those in darkness, "Appear."
They will graze by the roads,
and find pasture on every barren hill;
10 they shall not hunger nor thirst,
neither shall scorching heat nor sun strike them;
for he who has compassion on them will lead them,
and by springs of water he will guide them.[i]

11 And I will make all my mountains a road,
and my highways shall be raised up.
12 Behold, these shall come from afar,
and behold, these from the north and from the west,
and these from the land of Sinim.[j]
13 Shout for gladness, you heavens, and rejoice, you earth;
let the mountains burst into song!
For Yahweh has comforted his people,
and will have compassion on his afflicted.
14 But Zion said, “Yahweh has forsaken me;
the Lord has forgotten me.”
15 Can a woman forget her nursing child,
so as to have no pity on the son of her womb?
Even these may forget,
yet I will not forget you.
16 Look, I have carved you on the palms of my hands;
your walls are always in front of me.[k]
17 Your sons hurry back;
those who tore you down and wasted you depart from you.[l]
18 Look up and look all around;
they are all assembling and coming to you.
As surely as I live, declares Yahweh,
you will wear them all like jewelry
and fasten them on like a bride.
19 For your waste and your desolate places,
and your land that was ruined,
surely now you shall be too narrow for your inhabitants,
and those who swallowed you shall be far away.
20 The children born while you were bereaved will still say within earshot,
“This place is too crowded for me;
move over so I can live here.”[m]
21 Then you shall say in your heart,
“Who has begotten these for me,
when I was childless and barren,

an exile, and driven about?
And these, who reared them?
See, I was left by myself;
from where, then, are these?"
22 This is what the Lord Yahweh says:
I will raise my hand toward the nations
and lift my banner for the peoples;
they will carry your sons in their arms,
and your daughters will ride on their shoulders.[n]
23 Kings will be your foster fathers,
and their queens your nursing mothers;
they will bow down to you, faces to the ground,
and lick the dust off your feet.
And you will recognize that I am Yahweh;
no one who waits for me will be disappointed.
24 Shall plunder be seized from a warrior,
or a tyrant's captive slip away?[o]
25 For this is what Yahweh says:
Even the prisoners of a warrior will be taken back,
and the loot of a tyrant will be recovered;
I will fight those who fight you,
and I will rescue your children.
26 I will make your oppressors eat their own flesh,
and they shall be drunk with their own blood as with new wine.
Then all flesh shall know
that I am Yahweh your Savior,
and your Redeemer, the Mighty One of Jacob.[p]

Notes

- a (49:1) The second "Servant Song" (49:1–6); compare 42:1. Compare Jeremiah 1:5; Galatians 1:15.
- b (49:2) Compare Hebrews 4:12; Revelation 1:16.
- c (49:3) The servant is named Israel, yet has a mission to Israel (verses 5–6); interpreters have seen in him the ideal Israel, a faithful remnant, the prophet, or the Messiah. One medieval Hebrew manuscript is reported to lack "Israel."
- d (49:4) Hebrew tohu and hevel, "emptiness" and "vapor." Or "my reward," "my recompense."

- e (49:5) “To him” follows the read form of the Hebrew and the Great Isaiah Scroll; the written form has “not,” “and Israel is not gathered.” The Great Isaiah Scroll also reads “my help” for “my strength.”
- f (49:6) Hebrew netsire, “preserved ones.” Paul and Barnabas quote the end of the verse in Acts 13:47; compare Luke 2:32.
- g (49:7) Or “to one whose life is despised.” The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “Thus says the Lord Yahweh, your Redeemer, O Israel.”
- h (49:8) 2 Corinthians 6:2 quotes the first two lines.
- i (49:10) Compare Revelation 7:16–17.
- j (49:12) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “the land of the Syenites” (Seweniyim), that is, Syene, modern Aswan in southern Egypt, where there was a Jewish colony in the Persian period (compare Ezekiel 29:10). The standard Hebrew text has Sinim, otherwise unknown.
- k (49:16) Perhaps the plans of the rebuilt city, or a mark like a tattoo.
- l (49:17) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads bonayikh, “your builders,” for banayikh, “your sons,” the same consonants with a different vowel, a reading also reflected in some ancient versions; the builders outpace the destroyers. The Septuagint has “you shall soon be built.”
- m (49:20) Or “Give me room, that I may dwell.”
- n (49:22) Hebrew Adonai Yahweh. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads “For thus says Yahweh.”
- o (49:24) “A tyrant” follows the Great Isaiah Scroll (ʿarits), as in verse 25, and the Syriac and Latin Vulgate; the standard Hebrew text reads tsaddiq, “a righteous one” (perhaps “the captives of the victor”). The Septuagint has “a man taken captive unjustly.”
- p (49:26) Hebrew Avir Yaʿaqov, “the Mighty One of Jacob,” compare 1:24; Genesis 49:24.

Chapter 50

1 This is what Yahweh says:
Where is your mother’s certificate of divorce,
by which I dismissed her?
Or which of my creditors
received you as payment from me?
Look, you were sold for your own wrongs,
and your mother was dismissed for your rebellious acts.[a]
2 Why was there no one when I arrived?
Why did nobody reply when I called?
Is my hand too short to buy you back?
Do I lack the strength to rescue?

With a single rebuke I turn the sea into dry ground
and rivers into desert;
their fish stink for lack of water
and die of thirst.[b]
3 I clothe the heavens with blackness,
and make sackcloth their covering.
4 The Lord Yahweh has granted me
a disciple's tongue,
to know how to hold up the weary
with a word.
Each morning he rouses,
he wakens my ear
to hear as those who are taught.[c]
5 The Lord Yahweh has opened my ear,
and I was not rebellious;
I did not turn backward.
6 My back I offered to the smiters,
and my cheeks to them that tore out the hair;
my face I did not cover
from disgrace and spittle.[d]
7 But the Lord Yahweh helps me;
that is why I have not been humiliated;
that is why I have made my face hard as flint,
and I know I will not be ashamed.[e]
8 He who vindicates me is near.
Who will contend with me? Let us stand up together.
Who is my adversary? Let him come near to me.[f]
9 Behold, the Lord Yahweh helps me;
who is he who will condemn me?
Behold, all of them shall wear out like a garment;
the moth shall eat them up.
10 Who among you fears Yahweh
and listens to his servant's voice?
Let the person who walks in the dark
with no light at all

put his trust in Yahweh's name
and rely on his God.[g]
11 Look, all of you who light fires
and arm yourselves with torches:
go, walk in the glare of your fire
and among the torches you have lit!
This is what you will get from my hand:
you will lie down in torment.

Notes

- a (50:1) Compare Deuteronomy 24:1–4; Jeremiah 3:8; Hosea 2:2. The questions imply that there was no formal divorce and no debt; the exile was due to Israel's sins, and the bond can be restored.
- b (50:2) Compare Exodus 7:18, 21; 14:21.
- c (50:4) The third "Servant Song" (50:4–9). Hebrew limmudim, "disciples," "those who are taught"; compare 8:16. In verses 4, 5, 7, and 9, Hebrew Adonai Yahweh.
- d (50:6) Compare Matthew 26:67; 27:30; Mark 14:65. The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "I did not turn aside my face."
- e (50:7) Compare Ezekiel 3:8–9; Luke 9:51.
- f (50:8) Compare Romans 8:33–34.
- g (50:10) The Great Isaiah Scroll has plural forms: "who walk in darkness."

Chapter 51

1 Listen to me, you who pursue righteousness,
you who seek Yahweh:
look to the rock from which you were hewn,
and to the hollow of the pit from which you were dug.[a]
2 Consider Abraham your father,
and Sarah who gave you birth;
for I called him when he was one alone,
and I blessed him and made him many.[b]
3 For Yahweh has consoled Zion;
he has consoled all her ruined places;
he will make her desert like Eden
and her wasteland like Yahweh's garden;
joy and gladness will be found in her,
thanks and the sound of singing.[c]

4 Listen carefully, my people,
and hear me, my nation;
instruction will come out from me,
and I will set my justice as a light for the peoples.[d]
5 My righteousness is near;
my salvation has gone forth,
and my arms shall judge the peoples;
on me the coastlands wait,
and on my arm they set their hope.[e]
6 Raise your eyes to the sky
and look at the ground below;
the sky will disappear like smoke,
the earth will wear out like clothing,
and its people will die like flies;
but my deliverance will last forever,
and my righteousness will never fail.[f]
7 Listen to me, you who know what is right,
you people who have my instruction in your hearts;
do not be afraid of human scorn
or terrified by their insults.
8 For the moth shall eat them up like a garment,
and the worm shall eat them like wool;
but my righteousness shall be forever,
and my salvation to all generations.[g]
9 Awake, awake, put on strength,
O arm of Yahweh!
Awake, as in the ancient days,
the ages long past!
Are you not the one who hewed Rahab apart,
who ran the dragon through?[h]
10 Was it not you who dried up the sea,
the waters of the great deep,
who made the depths of the sea a way
for the redeemed to pass over?[i]

11 The people Yahweh has bought back will return
and come to Zion singing;
everlasting joy will be on their heads;
they will be filled with gladness and joy,
and sorrow and sighing will run off.[j]
12 I, I am the one who comforts you;
who are you to be afraid of a mortal who will die,
of a human being who is made like grass,[k]
13 and to forget Yahweh who made you,
who spread out the sky
and laid the earth's foundations,
and to live in constant dread all day
of the rage of the oppressor,
who is aiming to destroy?
But where is the oppressor's rage?
14 Soon shall the one stooped in bonds be set loose;
he shall not die in the pit,
and his bread shall not fail.[l]
15 For I am Yahweh your God,
who stirs up the sea so that its waves roar;
Yahweh of Armies is his name.[m]
16 I have placed my words in your mouth
and hidden you in the shade of my hand,
so that I may set up the heavens, lay the earth's foundations,
and say to Zion, "You are my people."[n]
17 Rouse yourself, rouse yourself,
stand up, O Jerusalem,
you who have drunk from the hand of Yahweh
the cup of his fury;
the goblet, the cup that makes men reel,
you have drunk it and drained it.[o]
18 Of all the sons she bore,
not one leads her;
of all the sons she raised,
not one grasps her hand.

19 These two disasters have struck you
(who will grieve with you?):
ruin and destruction, hunger and the sword;
how can I console you?[p]
20 Your sons have fainted;
they lie at the head of every street
like an antelope in a net;
they are full of the wrath of Yahweh,
the rebuke of your God.[q]
21 So hear this now, you afflicted one,
drunken, yet not from wine:
22 This is what your Lord Yahweh says,
your God, who pleads the case of his people:
Look, I have taken from your hand the cup that made you stagger,
the bowl of my wrath; you will never drink from it again;[r]
23 and I will set it in the hand of those who grieve you,
who said to your soul,
"Lie flat, so we can walk across";
and you made your back like the ground,
like a street for them to pass over.[s]

Notes

- a (51:1) Abraham and Sarah (verse 2) are the rock and the quarry from which Israel came.
- b (51:2) Compare Genesis 12:1–3; Ezekiel 33:24.
- c (51:3) Eden, Hebrew ʻeden, "delight" (Genesis 2:8). The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "sorrow and sighing shall flee away," as in verse 11.
- d (51:4) Or "law," Hebrew torah. Compare 2:3; 42:4.
- e (51:5) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "his arm shall judge the peoples; the coastlands wait for him, and for his arm they hope."
- f (51:6) Hebrew kemo-ken, perhaps "like gnats" (compare ken, "gnat") or "in like manner." Compare Psalm 102:25–26; Hebrews 1:10–12; 2 Peter 3:10.
- g (51:8) Compare 50:9.
- h (51:9) Rahab, Hebrew rahav, "boisterous one," "arrogance," a mythic sea monster and a poetic name for Egypt (30:7; Psalm 87:4; 89:10); not the same name as Rahab of Jericho (Hebrew rahav with a different h). "Sea monster," Hebrew tannin (27:1).
- i (51:10) The Red Sea crossing (Exodus 14:21–22).
- j (51:11) Repeated from 35:10.

- k (51:12) Compare 40:6–8.
- l (51:14) Or "He who is bound," Hebrew tso'eh, "one bent over," perhaps a prisoner in fetters.
- m (51:15) Compare Jeremiah 31:35.
- n (51:16) Some propose "to stretch out" (lintot) for "to plant" (linto'a).
- o (51:17) Compare Jeremiah 25:15–29; Revelation 14:10; 16:19.
- p (51:19) The Great Isaiah Scroll and the Septuagint read "who shall comfort you?"
- q (51:20) Hebrew te'o, a wild ox or antelope, perhaps the oryx (Deuteronomy 14:5).
- r (51:22) Hebrew Adonayikh Yahweh, "your Lord Yahweh."
- s (51:23) Or "Lie down, that we may walk over you." The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "and your oppressors" after "tormentors."

Chapter 52

1 Wake up, wake up,
clothe yourself with your strength, O Zion;
clothe yourself with your splendid garments,
O Jerusalem, the holy city;
for the uncircumcised and the unclean
shall no longer enter into you.
2 Shake off the dust and get up;
sit on your throne, Jerusalem;
undo the chains from your neck,
captive daughter of Zion.[a]
3 For thus says Yahweh: "For nothing you were sold, and not with silver shall you be redeemed." 4 For thus says the Lord Yahweh: "My people went down into Egypt at the first to sojourn there, and Assyria oppressed them for no cause.[b] 5 And now, what have I here?" declares Yahweh, "seeing that my people are taken away for nothing? Those who rule over them howl," declares Yahweh, "and continually, all the day long, my name is scorned.[c] 6 So my people will know my name; on that day they will know that I am the one who is speaking: here I am."
7 How lovely upon the mountains
are the feet of the herald of good news,
who makes peace heard, who brings tidings of good,
who makes salvation heard,
who says to Zion, "Your God reigns!"[d]

8 Hark, your watchmen! They lift up their voice;
together they cry out for joy;
for eye to eye they shall see
the return of Yahweh to Zion.[e]
9 Burst out together into singing,
you ruins of Jerusalem;
for Yahweh has comforted his people;
he has redeemed Jerusalem.
10 Yahweh has bared his holy arm
before the eyes of all the nations,
and all the ends of the earth shall see
the salvation of our God.
11 Turn away, turn away, go out from there;
touch nothing unclean;
go out from her midst; keep yourselves pure,
you who carry the vessels of Yahweh.[f]
12 For you shall not go out in haste,
nor shall you go in flight;
for Yahweh goes before you,
and the God of Israel is your rear guard.[g]
13 See, my servant shall act wisely;[h]
he shall be lifted up and exalted,
and shall be very high.[i]
14 Just as many were appalled at you[j]—
his look was so disfigured, past that of any man,[k]
and his shape past that of mankind—
15 so shall he sprinkle many nations;[l]
kings shall shut their mouths because of him;
for what was not told them they shall see,
and what they had not heard they shall understand.[m]

Notes

- a (52:2) "Take your seat": Hebrew shevi, "sit (enthroned)"; with different vowels, "O captive." "Loose" follows the read form of the Hebrew; the written form, which the Great Isaiah Scroll shares, has "they have loosed."
- b (52:4) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Thus says Yahweh," without "Lord."

- c (52:5) Or “wail,” or “boast.” The Septuagint has “on account of you my name is continually blasphemed among the Gentiles,” which Paul quotes in Romans 2:24.
- d (52:7) Romans 10:15 quotes the first two lines; compare Nahum 1:15 (2:1 in Hebrew) and 40:9.
- e (52:8) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “in compassion” (“when Yahweh returns to Zion in compassion”); compare the Septuagint, “when the Lord shall have mercy upon Zion.”
- f (52:11) Paul applies the verse to the church in 2 Corinthians 6:17.
- g (52:12) After “the God of Israel” the Great Isaiah Scroll adds “he shall be called the God of all the earth” (compare 54:5).
- h (52:13) The fourth “Servant Song” runs from 52:13 to 53:12. Hebrew yaskil, “act with insight,” and so “prosper”; the Septuagint has “shall understand.”
- i (52:13) Compare 6:1 and 57:15, where the same pair of words, “lifted up and exalted,” describes Yahweh himself. The Septuagint has “and be glorified exceedingly”; compare Acts 3:13.
- j (52:14) So the Masoretic Text and the Great Isaiah Scroll; some ancient versions are reported to read “at him.” In 1QIsa-b the word is lost.
- k (52:14) Hebrew mishhat, “disfigurement,” and 1QIsa-b agrees. The Great Isaiah Scroll writes the word with a final yod (mshhty), which some scholars read as mashahti, “I anointed”: “so I anointed his appearance beyond any man.” The Septuagint has “so shall your face be without glory from men.”
- l (52:15) Hebrew yazzeh, the verb used of sprinkling blood and water in rites of cleansing (Leviticus 4:6; 16:14; Numbers 19:18). The Septuagint has “so shall many nations wonder at him,” and some render “startle.”
- m (52:15) Romans 15:21 quotes the last two lines from the Septuagint.

Chapter 53

1 Who has believed what we have heard?[a]
And the arm of Yahweh, to whom has it been revealed?[b]
2 For he grew up before him like a young shoot,[c]
and like a root out of parched ground;
he had no form nor majesty that we should look upon him,
nor any appearance that we should desire him.
3 He was despised and forsaken by men,[d]
a man of pains, and acquainted with sickness;[e]
and as one from whom people hide their face
he was despised, and we did not esteem him.
4 Surely he has borne our sicknesses,
and carried our pains;

yet we ourselves accounted him stricken,
struck down by God, and afflicted.[f]
5 But he was wounded for our rebellion,[g]
crushed for our guilt;
the punishment that brought us peace fell on him,[h]
and through his wounds we are healed.[i]
6 All of us like sheep have wandered;
each one we have turned to his own way;
and Yahweh has made to fall on him
the iniquity of us all.[j]
7 He was oppressed, and he humbled himself,[k]
yet he opened not his mouth;
as a lamb led to the slaughter,
and as a ewe before her shearers is dumb,
so he opened not his mouth.[l]
8 Through oppression and a verdict he was taken away;[m]
who among his contemporaries thought about[n]
how he was cut off from the land of the living,
struck down for the rebellion of my people?[o]
9 And his grave was assigned with the wicked,[p]
and with a rich man in his death,[q]
though he had committed no violence,
nor was deceit found in his mouth.[r]
10 Yet it was the will of Yahweh to crush him;
he made him sick.[s]
When his life makes an offering for guilt,[t]
he shall see offspring, he shall prolong his days,
and the will of Yahweh shall prosper by his hand.
11 After his soul's anguish he will see light[u]
and be content;
through his knowledge[v] my righteous servant[w]
will make many people righteous,
and he will carry their guilt.
12 Therefore I will give him a portion among the many,[x]
and with the strong he shall share the spoil,[y]

because he poured out his soul to death
and was counted with the transgressors;[z]
yet he bore the sin of many,
and for the transgressors he intercedes.[aa]

Notes

- a (53:1) Or "our report," "our message." John 12:38 and Romans 10:16 quote this line.
- b (53:1) For "the arm of Yahweh," compare 51:9; 52:10.
- c (53:2) Hebrew yoneq, "a suckling," used of a shoot from a root; compare 11:1. The Septuagint has "we brought a report as of a child before him."
- d (53:3) Or "rejected by men"; Hebrew hadal ishim, perhaps "lacking men," that is, deserted, or "least of men."
- e (53:3) Hebrew holi, "sickness" (also verse 4), and makh'ovot, "pains."
- f (53:4) Matthew 8:17 quotes the first two lines of Jesus' healings. The Septuagint has "he bears our sins, and is pained for us." First Peter 2:24 draws on verses 4–5 and 12.
- g (53:5) Hebrew meholal, "pierced" or "wounded"; the Septuagint has "wounded."
- h (53:5) Hebrew musar shelomenu, "the discipline of our peace."
- i (53:5) Hebrew havurah, "stripe," "welt." Quoted in 1 Peter 2:24.
- j (53:6) Hebrew hifgia', "caused to strike," "caused to meet"; the same verb is rendered "intercedes" in verse 12. Compare 1 Peter 2:25.
- k (53:7) Or "and he was afflicted."
- l (53:7) Acts 8:32–33 quotes verses 7–8 from the Septuagint: this is the passage the Ethiopian official was reading when Philip met him. Compare Jeremiah 11:19; Matthew 26:63; 1 Peter 2:23.
- m (53:8) Hebrew me'otser umimmishpat, "from detention and from judgment"; or "without restraint and without justice." The Septuagint has "in his humiliation his judgment was taken away," as quoted in Acts 8:33.
- n (53:8) Or "who could tell of his descendants?" or "who gave thought to his fate?" The Septuagint has "who shall declare his generation? For his life is taken away from the earth."
- o (53:8) Hebrew nega' lamo, "a blow to them" (or "to him"). For "my people" the Great Isaiah Scroll reads "his people" ('ammo), and 1QIsa-b appears to read the same, though the final letter there is uncertain. The Septuagint has "because of the iniquities of my people he was led to death."
- p (53:9) Hebrew "he gave," that is, "one made"; the Great Isaiah Scroll reads "they gave." The Septuagint has "I will give the wicked for his burial."
- q (53:9) Hebrew bemotav, "in his deaths," a plural perhaps of intensity. The Great Isaiah Scroll writes bwmtw, which some scholars take as "his burial mound" or "his high place." Compare Matthew 27:57–60, where Joseph of Arimathea, "a rich man," buries Jesus.
- r (53:9) First Peter 2:22 quotes the last two lines, with "sin" for "violence."

- s (53:10) Hebrew hehli, “he made sick.” The Great Isaiah Scroll reads wayhalleluhu, which has been taken as “and he pierced him” (compare meholal, verse 5). The Septuagint has “the Lord also is pleased to purge him from his stroke.”
- t (53:10) Or “if you make his soul a guilt offering”; the Hebrew verb can be “you make” or “she (his soul) makes.” Hebrew asham, the guilt offering of Leviticus 5:14–6:7.
- u (53:11) “Light” follows the Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa-a) and 1QIsa-b, both of which read yir’eh ’or, “he shall see light,” and the Septuagint, “to show him light.” A third Qumran copy, 4QIsa-d, is reported to read “light” as well. The Masoretic Text lacks the word: “he shall see, he shall be satisfied.”
- v (53:11) Or “by knowledge of him,” or “by his humiliation.”
- w (53:11) So the Masoretic Text and, as far as legible, 1QIsa-b; the Great Isaiah Scroll reads “his servant.” The Septuagint has “to justify the just one who serves many well.”
- x (53:12) Or “with the great.” The Septuagint has “he shall inherit many.”
- y (53:12) Or “and he shall divide the mighty as spoil.”
- z (53:12) Jesus quotes this line of himself in Luke 22:37; some manuscripts of Mark 15:28 apply it to the crucifixion between two criminals.
- aa (53:12) Hebrew yafgia‘, “he makes intercession” (see the note on verse 6). The Great Isaiah Scroll and 1QIsa-b read “for their transgressions”; the Septuagint has “and was delivered because of their iniquities.”

Chapter 54

1 “Sing, you childless woman who never gave birth;
break into song and shout, you who never felt labor pains!
For the children of the abandoned woman are more
than those of the woman with a husband,” says Yahweh.[a]
2 “Widen the place of your tent,
and let the curtains of your dwellings be stretched out; do not hold back;
make your cords long and your stakes strong.
3 For to the right hand and to the left you shall break out,
and your offspring shall dispossess nations
and make desolate cities to be inhabited.
4 Do not be afraid, for you will not be ashamed;
do not be dismayed, for you will not be humiliated;
you will forget the disgrace of your youth,
and no longer remember the shame of your widowhood.

5 For your Maker is your husband,[b]
Yahweh of Armies is his name;
and the Holy One of Israel is your Redeemer;
he is called the God of all the earth.
6 For as a wife forsaken and grieved in spirit Yahweh has called you,
and as a wife of youth when she is rejected," says your God.
7 "For a little moment I abandoned you,
yet in great mercies I will gather you in.
8 In a surge of anger[c] I hid my face from you for a moment,
but with everlasting loyal love I will have mercy on you,"
says Yahweh, your Redeemer.
9 "This is like the days of Noah to me:[d]
just as I promised that the waters of Noah
would never again flood the earth,
so I promise that I will not be angry with you
or scold you.
10 Though mountains may move
and hills be shaken,
my loyal love will never leave you,
and the covenant of peace I made will stand,"
says Yahweh, who has mercy on you.
11 "O afflicted one, storm-tossed, not comforted,
see, I will set your stones in antimony,[e]
and lay your foundations with sapphires.[f]
12 I will make your battlements of rubies,[g]
and your gates of carbuncles,
and all your border of precious stones.
13 All your sons shall be taught by Yahweh,[h]
and great shall be the peace of your sons.[i]
14 You will be established on a foundation of righteousness;
stay far from oppression, for you have nothing to fear,
and far from terror, for it will not approach you.
15 Should any assail you, it is not my doing;[j]
whoever assails you shall fall on your account.

16 Look, I am the one who made the blacksmith
who fans the charcoal fire
and forges a weapon for his purpose;
I also made the destroyer who ruins.
17 No weapon formed against you shall succeed,
and every tongue that rises against you in judgment you shall condemn.[k]
This is the inheritance of the servants of Yahweh,
and their vindication from me," declares Yahweh.
the Septuagint has "strangers shall come to you by me."

Notes

- a (54:1) Paul quotes the verse in Galatians 4:27.
- b (54:5) Hebrew bo'alayikh, "your husband," plural in form (a plural of majesty), like "your Maker."
- c (54:8) Hebrew shetsef qetsef, a play on sound, "a gush of fury."
- d (54:9) Or, with the Hebrew letters divided differently (kime for ki me), "as the days of Noah"; the Great Isaiah Scroll appears to read so, though the letters are uncertain.
- e (54:11) Hebrew pukh, the black paint used for the eyes, here a dark mortar that sets off the stones. The Septuagint has "carbuncle."
- f (54:11) Or "lapis lazuli." Compare Revelation 21:18–21.
- g (54:12) The identity of these stones (Hebrew kadkod and eqdah) is uncertain.
- h (54:13) Jesus quotes this line in John 6:45.
- i (54:13) For the second "your sons" (banayikh) the Great Isaiah Scroll has a waw added above the line, giving bonayikh, "your builders"; compare 49:17.
- j (54:15) Hebrew gur yagur, "stir up strife," "attack," or "sojourn";
- k (54:17) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks this line.

Chapter 55

1 "Ho! All you who are thirsty, come to the waters;
and you that have no silver, come, buy grain and eat!
Yes, come, buy wine and milk
for no silver and for no price.[a]
2 Why do you weigh out silver for what is not bread,
and your labor for that which never satisfies?
Hear me attentively, and eat that which is good,
and let your soul delight itself in fatness.

3 Bend your ear and come to me;
hearken, and your soul shall live;
and I will cut for you a covenant forever,
the faithful mercies of David.[b]
4 See, I made him a witness to the peoples,
a prince and commander for the peoples.
5 You will summon a nation you have never known,
and a nation that never knew you will hurry to you,
because of Yahweh your God, the Holy One of Israel,
who has made you glorious.
6 Seek Yahweh while he lets himself be found;
call upon him while he is near.
7 Let the wicked forsake his way,
and the man of iniquity his thoughts;
and let him return to Yahweh, that he may have compassion on him,
and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon.
8 For my thoughts are not your thoughts,
neither are your ways my ways, declares Yahweh.
9 For as the heavens are higher than the earth,
so my ways are higher than your ways,
and my thoughts than your thoughts.
10 For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven
and return not there, but water the earth
and make it bring forth and sprout,
and give seed to the sower and bread to the eater,[c]
11 so shall my word be that goes forth from my mouth;
it shall not return to me empty,
but it shall do what I desire,
and succeed in that for which I sent it.
12 For in joy you shall go out,
and in peace you shall be led forth;
the mountains and the hills shall break out before you into song,
and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands.

13 Instead of the thornbush the cypress shall come up;
instead of the brier the myrtle shall come up;
and it shall be to Yahweh for a name,[d]
for an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off."

Notes

- a (55:1) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "and eat; come, buy," probably because the copyist's eye skipped from one "buy" to the next.
- b (55:3) Hebrew hasde dawid hanne'emanim, "the sure acts of loyal love promised to David"; compare 2 Samuel 7:15–16. Acts 13:34 quotes the line from the Septuagint, "the holy and sure things of David."
- c (55:10) Compare 2 Corinthians 9:10.
- d (55:13) Hebrew leshem, "for renown."

Chapter 56

1 Thus says Yahweh:
"Keep justice and do righteousness,
for near is my salvation to come,
and my righteousness to be revealed.[a]
2 Blessed is the man who does this,
and the son of man who holds fast to it,
who keeps the Sabbath so as not to profane it,
and keeps his hand from doing any evil."
3 Let no foreigner who has joined himself to Yahweh say,
"Yahweh will surely keep me apart from his people";
and let no eunuch say,
"Look, I am only a dry tree."
4 For thus says Yahweh:
"To the eunuchs who keep my Sabbaths,
who choose the things in which I delight
and hold fast my covenant,
5 I will give in my house and within my walls
a monument and a name[b]
better than sons and daughters;
I will give them an everlasting name
that shall not be cut off.

6 “As for the foreigners who attach themselves to Yahweh,
to serve him, to love Yahweh’s name
and to be his servants,
all who keep the Sabbath without desecrating it
and hold firmly to my covenant,
7 those I will bring to my holy mountain
and fill with joy in my house of prayer;
their burnt offerings and other sacrifices
will be accepted on my altar;[c]
for my house will be called a house of prayer
for all the peoples.”[d]
8 The Lord Yahweh declares,
who gathers the outcasts of Israel,
“I will yet gather others to him
besides those already gathered.”[e]
9 All you beasts of the field, come to devour,
all you beasts in the forest.
10 His watchmen are blind;[f]
none of them has knowledge;
they are all mute dogs;
they cannot bark;
dreaming,[g] lying down,
loving to slumber.
11 The dogs are greedy of soul;[h]
they never know when they have enough.
And these are shepherds
who have no understanding;
all of them have turned to their own way,
each to his own gain, to the last man.
12 “Come,” they say, “I will fetch wine,[i]
and let us drink our fill of strong drink;
and tomorrow shall be as today,
great beyond all measure.”

Notes

- a (56:1) The Great Isaiah Scroll begins the chapter with “For.”

- b (56:5) Hebrew yad vashem, literally “a hand and a name.”
- c (56:7) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “shall go up,” that is, “shall go up for acceptance on my altar.”
- d (56:7) Jesus quotes the last two lines when he clears the temple (Mark 11:17; compare Matthew 21:13; Luke 19:46).
- e (56:8) Compare John 10:16.
- f (56:10) The written form of the Hebrew has “His watchman.”
- g (56:10) Hebrew hozim, perhaps “panting” or “raving”; the Great Isaiah Scroll reads “they are seers” (hozim, spelled differently), a bitter play on the prophets. The Septuagint has “dreaming of rest.”
- h (56:11) Or “are strong of appetite.”
- i (56:12) So the Masoretic Text; the Great Isaiah Scroll reads “let us take wine.”

Chapter 57

1 The righteous man perishes,
and no one takes it to heart;
devout men are gathered away,
while none understands
that from the face of evil
the righteous man is gathered away.
2 He enters into peace;
they rest upon their beds,
each one who walks straight ahead.[a]
3 “But you, come near here,
sons of a sorceress,
offspring of an adulterer and of one who plays the harlot.[b]
4 At whom do you make sport?
Against whom do you open wide the mouth
and thrust out the tongue?
Are you not a brood of rebellion,
offspring of deceit,
5 you who burn with lust among the oaks,[c]
under every green tree,
who slay the children in the valleys,
under the clefts of the crags?
6 Among the smooth stones of the valley is your portion;[d]
they, they are your lot;

to them also you have poured out a drink offering,
you have brought up a grain offering.
Shall I be consoled over these things?
7 Upon a high and lofty mountain
you have set your bed;
there also you went up
to offer sacrifice.
8 Behind the door and the doorpost
you have set your memorial;[e]
for, deserting me, you uncovered your bed,
you went up onto it, you made it wide;
and you made a bargain for yourself with them;
you loved their bed;
you gazed upon a hand.[f]
9 You went down to the king[g] with oil,
and made your ointments many;
you dispatched your messengers to distant parts,
and debased yourself as far as Sheol.
10 You were tired out by your long journey,
but you never said, 'There is no use';
you found renewed strength,
so you did not give out.
11 "Whom did you dread and fear,
that you lied,
and did not remember me,
nor lay it to your heart?
Have I not kept silent, and that from of old,[h]
and so you fear me not?
12 I will declare your righteousness and your deeds,
but they shall not profit you.[i]
13 When you cry for help,
let your gathered hoard rescue you!
But the wind shall lift them all away;
a breath shall take them away.

But he who takes refuge in me shall possess the land
and inherit my holy mountain."
14 And one shall say,
"Build up, build up, clear the way;[j]
lift every stumbling block
out of the way of my people."
15 For this is what the lofty and exalted One says,
who inhabits eternity, whose name is Holy:
"I live in a high and sacred place,
yet I am also with those who are crushed and humble in spirit,
revitalizing the humble spirit
and reviving the crushed heart.
16 For I will not contend forever,
nor will I always be angry;
for then the spirit would grow faint before me,
even the breath of life that I have made.[k]
17 Because of his sinful greed I was angry;
I struck him, hid my face and was furious;
yet he kept on turning away,
following his own heart's path.
18 I have seen his ways, and I will heal him;
I will lead him and restore comfort to him[l]
and to those who mourn for him,
19 I create the fruit of the lips.[m]
Peace, peace to those far away and to those near,"
says Yahweh, "and I will heal them."[n]
20 But the wicked are like the tossing sea,
for it cannot be still,
and its waters cast up mire and mud.
21 "There is no peace," says my God, "for the wicked."[o]

Notes

- a (57:2) Or "each who walks in his uprightness."
- b (57:3) Hebrew "and she plays the harlot."
- c (57:5) Or "who inflame yourselves among the terebinths" or "among the gods."

- d (57:6) There is a play on words in the Hebrew: helqe nahal, “smooth stones of the valley,” and helqekh, “your portion.”
- e (57:8) Probably a pagan symbol in place of the reminder of the law commanded in Deuteronomy 6:9.
- f (57:8) “A hand” may be a euphemism for the male member.
- g (57:9) Hebrew melekh, or perhaps Molech (compare Leviticus 18:21).
- h (57:11) Or, with a slight change of the Hebrew, “and hidden my eyes.”
- i (57:12) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “your collection,” anticipating verse 13.
- j (57:14) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “the highway.” Compare 40:3; 62:10.
- k (57:16) Hebrew neshamot, “breaths,” the breath of life.
- l (57:18) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks “I will lead him” and reads “I will repay him with consolations.”
- m (57:19) The written form of the Hebrew has nov, the read form niv; both mean “fruit” of the lips, that is, praise. The Great Isaiah Scroll has “peace” once.
- n (57:19) Paul echoes this line in Ephesians 2:17.
- o (57:21) Compare 48:22.

Chapter 58

1 “Cry with a full throat, do not hold back;
lift up your voice like a ram’s horn;[a]
tell my people their transgression,
and the house of Jacob their sins.
2 Still they look for me every day
and take delight in learning my ways,
like a nation that has done right
and has not abandoned its God’s justice;
they ask me for fair rulings
and take pleasure in coming close to God.
3 ‘Why have we fasted,’ they say, ‘and you do not see?
Why have we humbled our souls, and you take no notice?’
See, in the day of your fast you pursue your own business,
and drive hard all your workers.[b]
4 See, you fast for quarrel and strife,
and to hit out with the fist of wickedness.
You do not fast as on this day
to have your voice heard on high.
5 Is that the sort of fast I choose,
a day when someone humbles himself?

Is it hanging your head like a reed
and spreading out sackcloth and ashes to lie on?
Do you really call this a fast,
a day Yahweh will accept?
6 "Is not this the fast that I choose:
to loosen the fetters of wickedness,
to untie the cords of the yoke,
to send away the crushed as free,[c]
and that you break every yoke?
7 Is it not to share your bread with the hungry,
and to bring the wandering poor home with you;
that when you see one naked you clothe him,[d]
and do not turn away from your own kin?
8 Then your light shall burst forth like the dawn,
and your healing shall sprout up quickly;
your righteousness shall go before you;
the glory of Yahweh shall gather you in behind.[e]
9 Then you will call, and Yahweh will answer;
you will cry for help, and he will say, 'Here I am.'
If you remove the yoke from among you,
the pointing finger and the malicious talk,
10 if you spend yourselves for the hungry
and satisfy the need of the afflicted,
your light will shine in the dark,
and your night will turn into noon.
11 And Yahweh will guide you always
and satisfy your soul in scorched places
and make your bones strong;
and you shall be like a watered garden,
like a spring of water
whose waters never fail.
12 Your people will rebuild the old ruins
and raise up foundations from past generations;
you will be known as the one who repairs gaps in walls
and restores streets to live on.

13 “If you turn back your foot from the Sabbath,
from doing your pleasure on my holy day,
and call the Sabbath a delight,
the holy day of Yahweh honorable,
and honor it, not going your own ways,
nor seeking your own pleasure, nor speaking idle words,
14 then you shall take delight in Yahweh,
and I will set you riding on the high places of the land,
and nourish you with the inheritance of Jacob your father,
for the mouth of Yahweh has spoken.”

Notes

- a (58:1) Hebrew shofar.
- b (58:3) Or “and exact all your debts.”
- c (58:6) Luke 4:18 includes this line in Jesus’ reading in Nazareth, from the Septuagint, “to set at liberty those who are oppressed.”
- d (58:7) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds “with a garment.”
- e (58:8) Or “shall be your rear guard”; compare 52:12.

Chapter 59

1 Look, Yahweh’s arm is not too short to save,
and his ear is not too deaf to hear;
2 but your iniquities have made a division
between you and your God,
and your sins have hidden his face from you,
so that he does not hear.
3 For your hands are stained with blood,
and your fingers with iniquity;
your lips have spoken falsehood;[a]
your tongue murmurs wrong.
4 No one sues justly;
no one goes to law honestly;
they trust in emptiness, they speak lies;
they conceive trouble and give birth to iniquity.
5 They hatch the eggs of vipers;
they weave the spider’s web;

he that eats of their eggs dies,
and the one that is crushed bursts into an adder.
6 Their threads shall not become a garment,
nor shall they clothe themselves with their handiwork.
Their doings are doings of iniquity,
and the work of violence is in their palms.
7 Their feet run to evil,
and they make haste to shed innocent blood;
their thoughts are thoughts of iniquity;
ruin and destruction are on their highways.[b]
8 The way of peace they know not,
and there is no justice in their tracks;
they have made their paths crooked for themselves;
no one who walks in them knows peace.
9 Therefore justice is far from us,
and righteousness does not reach us;
we wait for light, and see, darkness;
for brightness, and we walk in gloom.
10 We feel our way along the wall like the blind;
we grope as if we had no eyes;
we trip in broad daylight as if at dusk;
among the healthy we are like the dead.[c]
11 We roar, all of us, like bears,
and like doves we keep mourning;
we look for judgment, and there is none,
for deliverance, and it stays far off from us.
12 For our transgressions are many before you,
and our sins bear witness against us;
for our transgressions are with us,
and we know our iniquities:
13 transgressing, and denying Yahweh,
and turning back from following our God,
speaking oppression and revolt,
conceiving and uttering from the heart words of falsehood.

14 Justice is pushed backward,
and righteousness keeps its distance;
for truth has fallen in the street,
and uprightness cannot enter.
15 Truth is gone,
and whoever turns from evil becomes a target.
Yahweh saw it, and it displeased him
that there was no justice.
16 He saw that there was no man,
and was astonished that none stepped in;
so his arm wrought deliverance for him,
and his own righteousness sustained him.
17 He put on righteousness like body armor,
and placed a helmet of salvation on his head;[d]
he put on clothes of vengeance
and wrapped himself in zeal like a cloak.
18 As their deeds deserve, so shall he pay back:
fury to his foes, requital to his enemies;
to the coastlands he will render recompense.
19 People from the west will fear Yahweh's name,
and those from the east his glory;
for he will arrive like a rushing river,[e]
driven by the breath of Yahweh.
20 "And to Zion a Redeemer shall come,
and to them that turn from rebellion in Jacob," declares Yahweh.[f]
21 "And as for me, this is my covenant with them," says Yahweh: "My Spirit that is upon you, and my words that I have put in your mouth, shall not depart out of your mouth, nor out of the mouth of your offspring, nor out of the mouth of your offspring's offspring," says Yahweh,[g] "from this time forth and forevermore."

Notes

- a (59:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks this line; 1QIsa-b has it.
- b (59:7) Paul quotes verses 7–8 in Romans 3:15–17.
- c (59:10) The meaning of Hebrew ashmannim, "among the vigorous," is uncertain.
- d (59:17) Compare Ephesians 6:14, 17; 1 Thessalonians 5:8.

- e (59:19) Or “when the enemy comes like a river, the Spirit of Yahweh lifts a banner against him.”
- f (59:20) Paul quotes verses 20–21 in Romans 11:26–27 in a form close to the Septuagint, “the deliverer shall come for Zion’s sake, and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob”; Paul has “from Zion.”
- g (59:21) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks this second “says Yahweh”; 1QIsa-b has it.

Chapter 60

1 Get up, shine, for your light has arrived,
and Yahweh’s glory has dawned on you.
2 For see, darkness shall cover the earth,
and deep gloom the peoples;
but upon you Yahweh will rise,
and his glory shall be seen upon you.
3 And nations shall walk to your light,
and kings to the brightness of your dawning.
4 Lift up your eyes round about, and see;
they all gather together, they come to you;
your sons shall come from far off,
and your daughters shall be carried on the hip.[a]
5 Then you will look and glow with joy;
your heart will pound and swell,
because the riches of the sea will be brought to you
and the wealth of nations will come to you.
6 Throngs of camels shall cover you,
young camels from Midian and Ephah;
they shall all come from Sheba,
bearing gold and frankincense,
and they shall announce the praises of Yahweh.[b]
7 All the sheep of Kedar will be collected for you;
the rams of Nebaioth will serve you;
they will be accepted as offerings on my altar,[c]
and I will make my glorious house even more glorious.
8 Who are these that fly along as a cloud,
as doves to their lattices?

9 The coastlands are waiting for me,
with the ships of Tarshish in the lead,
bringing your children from far away,
together with their silver and gold,
to honor the name of Yahweh your God,
the Holy One of Israel,
for he has made you glorious.
10 Foreigners will rebuild your walls,
and their kings will serve you;
though in anger I struck you down,
in kindness I have shown you mercy.
11 Your gates shall stand open always;
by day and by night they shall never be closed,
that men may bring to you the wealth of the nations,
with their kings led in procession.[d]
12 Any nation or kingdom
that refuses to serve you will be destroyed;
such nations will be completely ruined.
13 The splendor of Lebanon will come to you,
its cypress, plane and pine trees together,
to adorn my sanctuary;
and I will honor the place where I rest my feet.
14 The sons of your oppressors
shall come to you bowed low,
and all that scorned you shall fall down at the soles of your feet;[e]
they shall call you the City of Yahweh,
the Zion of the Holy One of Israel.
15 Instead of your being abandoned and hated,
so that none went through you,
I will make you an eternal pride,
the joy of generation after generation.
16 You will drink the milk of nations
and nurse at the breasts of kings;
then you will know that I, Yahweh, am your Savior
and Redeemer, the Mighty One of Jacob.

17 For bronze I will bring in gold,
for iron I will bring in silver,
for timber, bronze,
for stones, iron;
and I will appoint peace as your overseers
and your taskmasters righteousness.
18 Violence will no longer be heard of in your country,
or devastation and destruction inside your borders;
you will name your walls Salvation
and your gates Praise.
19 You will no longer have the sun for light by day,
or the moon to brighten the night;[f]
Yahweh will be your light forever,
and your God will be your glory.[g]
20 Your sun shall no more go down,
nor shall your moon withdraw;
for Yahweh shall be your everlasting light,
and the days of your mourning shall be ended.
21 And your people, every one of them righteous,
shall inherit the land for all time,
the shoot of my planting, the work of my hands,
that I may be glorified.[h]
22 The least one shall become a thousand,
and the smallest a mighty nation;
I am Yahweh; in its time I will hasten it.

Notes

- a (60:4) Hebrew "nursed upon the side."
- b (60:6) Compare Matthew 2:11.
- c (60:7) So the Great Isaiah Scroll ("and they shall go up for acceptance"); the Masoretic Text has "they shall go up on acceptance, my altar."
- d (60:11) Or "with their kings leading them"; compare Revelation 21:25–26.
- e (60:14) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "all" before "the sons" and an erased word after it.
- f (60:19) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "by night": "nor for brightness by night shall the moon give you light"; compare the Septuagint, "nor shall the rising of the moon lighten your night." 1QIsa-b agrees with the Masoretic Text in lacking "by night."

- g (60:19) Or “your glory.” Compare Revelation 21:23; 22:5. 1QIsa-b is reported to end the verse at “everlasting light,” without this last line.
- h (60:21) The written form of the Hebrew has “his planting.”

Chapter 61

1 The Spirit of the Lord Yahweh is upon me,[a]
for Yahweh has anointed me
to announce glad tidings to the lowly;
he has sent me to bandage the broken in heart,
to cry freedom for the captives,
and the opening of the prison to those who are bound;[b]
2 to proclaim the year of Yahweh’s favor,
and the day of vengeance of our God;[c]
to comfort all who mourn;
3 and to give those who grieve in Zion
a crown in place of ashes,[d]
joyful oil in place of mourning,
a robe of praise in place of a faint spirit;
they will be named oaks of righteousness,
Yahweh’s own planting, to display his glory.
4 They will rebuild the ancient ruins;
they will restore places devastated long ago;
they will repair the ruined cities,
wasted for many generations.
5 Strangers shall stand and shepherd your flocks;
foreigners shall be your plowmen and your vinedressers;
6 but you shall be called the priests of Yahweh;[e]
men shall speak of you as the ministers of our God;
you shall eat the wealth of the nations,
and in their glory you shall boast.[f]
7 Instead of your shame there shall be a double portion,
and instead of disgrace they shall shout for joy over their lot;
so in their own land they shall inherit twice over;
joy without end shall be theirs.[g]

8 For I, Yahweh, love justice;
I hate robbery with wrongdoing;[h]
and I will faithfully give them their recompense,
and make an everlasting covenant with them.
9 Their offspring shall be known among the nations,
and their descendants in the midst of the peoples;
all who see them shall acknowledge them,
that they are an offspring Yahweh has blessed.
10 I will greatly rejoice in Yahweh;
my soul shall exult in my God;
for he has clothed me with the garments of salvation;
he has wrapped me in the robe of righteousness,
as a bridegroom adorns himself like a priest with a headdress,[i]
and as a bride decks herself with her jewels.
11 For as the earth brings forth its growth,
and as a garden makes what is sown in it spring up,
so the Lord Yahweh will make righteousness and praise
spring up before all the nations.[j]

Notes

- a (61:1) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "The Spirit of Yahweh," without "Lord"; 1QIsa-b reads "The Spirit of Yahweh God" (Yahweh Elohim). The Septuagint has "The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me; he has sent me to preach good tidings to the poor." Jesus reads verses 1–2a in the synagogue at Nazareth (Luke 4:18–19) in a form close to the Septuagint, and declares, "Today this scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing." For the anointed one (Hebrew mashiah), compare 11:2; 42:1; 45:1.
- b (61:1) Hebrew peqah-qoah, "opening, opening," perhaps "release" from the dark of prison (compare 42:7); the Great Isaiah Scroll writes it as one word. The Septuagint has "and recovery of sight to the blind," which Luke 4:18 includes.
- c (61:2) Jesus' reading in Luke 4:19 stops before this line. Compare 34:8; 63:4.
- d (61:3) There is a play on sound in the Hebrew: pe'er, "garland," for efer, "ashes."
- e (61:6) Compare Exodus 19:6; 1 Peter 2:9; Revelation 1:6.
- f (61:6) Or "and to their glory you shall succeed."
- g (61:7) The Great Isaiah Scroll has the second person, "instead of disgrace you shall rejoice in your portion … you shall possess a double portion; everlasting joy shall be yours."
- h (61:8) Or, with different vowels, "robbery with burnt offering." The Septuagint has "robberies of injustice."

- i (61:10) Hebrew yekhahen pe'er, "acts as priest with a turban."
- j (61:11) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "Yahweh God" for "the Lord Yahweh."

Chapter 62

1 Because of Zion I will not hold my peace,
and because of Jerusalem I will not rest,
till her righteousness shines out like the dawn,
and her salvation like a blazing torch.
2 And nations shall behold your righteousness,
and every king your glory;
and a new name shall be given you,
which Yahweh's own mouth shall designate.[a]
3 You shall be a crown of beauty in the hand of Yahweh,
and a royal turban in the palm of your God.[b]
4 No longer shall you be named Forsaken,[c]
and your land shall no longer be named Desolate;[d]
but you shall be called Hephzibah,[e]
and your land Beulah;[f]
for Yahweh delights in you,
and your land shall be married.
5 For as a youth weds a maiden,
your sons shall wed you;[g]
and with the joy of a bridegroom over his bride
your God shall rejoice over you.
6 I have posted guards on your walls,
Jerusalem;
they will never be quiet,
day or night.
You who remind Yahweh,
do not give yourselves any rest,
7 and allow him no rest
till he sets Jerusalem firm
and makes her a renown in the land.[h]
8 Yahweh has taken an oath by his right hand
and by the arm of his strength:

"I will not again give your grain
to be food for your enemies,
and the sons of foreigners shall not drink your new wine
for which you have toiled;
9 but those who gather it in shall eat it
and praise Yahweh,
and those who collect it shall drink it
in the courts of my sanctuary."[i]
10 Go through, go through the gates;
clear the way for the people;
build up, build up the highway;
clear it of stones;
lift up a banner over the peoples.[j]
11 Look, Yahweh has announced
to the ends of the earth:
Tell Zion's daughter,
"Look, your savior is coming;[k]
his reward comes with him,
and his payment goes before him."
12 And they shall call them The Holy People,
The Redeemed of Yahweh;
and you shall be called Sought Out,
A City Not Forsaken.

Notes

- a (62:2) Compare 65:15; Revelation 2:17; 3:12.
- b (62:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "and a turban."
- c (62:4) Hebrew Azuvah.
- d (62:4) Hebrew Shemamah.
- e (62:4) Hephzibah means "My Delight Is in Her"; it was also the name of King Manasseh's mother (2 Kings 21:1).
- f (62:4) Beulah means "Married."
- g (62:5) Or, with different vowels, "so shall your Builder marry you" (bonayikh for banayikh); compare 49:17; 54:13.
- h (62:7) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "and until he sets up."
- i (62:9) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "says your God" at the end.
- j (62:10) For the last line the Great Isaiah Scroll reads "clear away the stone of stumbling; say among the peoples." 1QIsa-b agrees with the Masoretic Text.

- k (62:11) Compare 40:10. Matthew 21:5 combines “Say to the daughter of Zion” with Zechariah 9:9.

Chapter 63

1 Who is this coming from Edom,[a]
  from Bozrah[b] with garments stained crimson,
  so majestic in his clothing,
  marching in his great strength?[c]
  “It is I, announcing victory,
  mighty to save.”
2 Why is there red upon your clothing,
  and your garments as of one treading the vat?
3 “I have trampled the winepress by myself,
  and no one from the nations was with me;
  I stomped on them in my anger
  and crushed them in my fury;
  their blood splashed on my clothes,
  and I stained all my garments.[d]
4 For a day of vengeance was in my heart,
  and the year of my redeemed ones had arrived.
5 I looked, but there was no helper;
  I was astonished, but there was none to uphold;
  so my own arm brought me salvation,
  and my fury, it upheld me.
6 I trod down the peoples in my anger;
  I made them drunk in my fury,
  and I poured out their juice upon the earth.”[e]
7 I will tell of Yahweh’s faithful acts of love
  and his praiseworthy deeds,
  all that Yahweh has done for us,
  and the great kindness toward the house of Israel
  that he showed them out of his mercy
  and his abundant love.

8 He said, “They are certainly my people,
children who will not betray me”;
and so he became their Savior.
9 In all their suffering he suffered too,[f]
and the angel who served in his presence rescued them;
in his love and mercy he bought them back;
he picked them up and carried them
through all the days of long ago.
10 But they rebelled
and grieved his Holy Spirit;[g]
so he turned to be their enemy,
and he himself fought against them.
11 Then they remembered the days of long ago,
of Moses and his people.[h]
Where is the one who brought them up from the sea
along with the shepherds of his flock?[i]
Where is the one who placed within them
his Holy Spirit,
12 who sent his glorious arm
to march at Moses’ right hand,
who divided the water in front of them
to make an everlasting name for himself,
13 who led them through the depths?
Like a horse in the open country,
they did not stumble.
14 Like livestock that go down into the valley,
the Spirit of Yahweh gave them rest.
So you led your people,
to make for yourself a glorious name.
15 Gaze down from heaven and behold,
from your dwelling of holiness and splendor.
Where is your zeal, and where your might?
The stirring of your inward parts and your compassion
are held back from me.

16 For you are our Father,
though Abraham does not know us,
and Israel does not acknowledge us;
you, Yahweh, are our Father;
our Redeemer from of old is your name.[j]
17 O Yahweh, why do you make us stray from your ways,
and make our heart hard against fearing you?
Turn back for your servants' sake,
for the tribes that are your heritage.
18 For a little while your holy people possessed it;[k]
our adversaries have trampled down your sanctuary.
19 We have become like those over whom you have never ruled,
like those who were not called by your name.[l]

Notes

- a (63:1) Edom, "red"; compare Genesis 25:30. The figure of the bloodied warrior is taken up in Revelation 19:13–15.
- b (63:1) Bozrah, a chief city of Edom; the name sounds like batsir, "grape harvest."
- c (63:1) Hebrew tso'eh, "bending," perhaps "striding"; with a slight change, "marching."
- d (63:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "I trod them in my anger … on my garments," probably because the copyist's eye skipped between similar words; 1QIsa-b has the lines. Compare Revelation 14:19–20; 19:15.
- e (63:6) Many Hebrew manuscripts and the Targum are reported to read "I shattered them" (ashabberem) for "I made them drunk" (ashakkerem).
- f (63:9) The written form of the Hebrew has "not" (lo'), the read form "to him" (lo); the written form may be taken "In all their distress he did not afflict" or, joined to the next line with the Septuagint, "not an envoy nor an angel, but his own presence saved them." The Great Isaiah Scroll has neither word. The Septuagint reads "not an ambassador, nor a messenger, but himself saved them."
- g (63:10) Compare Ephesians 4:30.
- h (63:11) Or "Then his people remembered the days of old, of Moses."
- i (63:11) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint has "the shepherd of the sheep."
- j (63:16) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "he" ("our Redeemer from of old, he is your name").
- k (63:18) Or "possessed your sanctuary."
- l (63:19) In the Hebrew text this verse continues with the line that English Bibles number 64:1.

Chapter 64

1 If only you would rend the heavens and descend,
so that the mountains shook before you,[a]
2 as when fire sets brushwood ablaze
and fire makes the water boil,
to make your name known to your adversaries,
that the nations might tremble at your presence!
3 When you did fearful deeds we had not hoped for,
you descended; the mountains shook before you.[b]
4 Since ages past no one has heard,
no ear has caught it,
nor has eye beheld any God but you
who works on behalf of him who waits for him.[c]
5 You come to the aid of those who gladly do right,
who remember you as they follow your ways.
But you were angry, and we sinned;
we have been in sin for a long time, so can we be saved?[d]
6 We have all become like one who is unclean,
and all our righteous deeds are like a stained garment.[e]
We all wither like a leaf,
and our iniquities, like the wind, carry us away.
7 None calls on your name;
none stirs himself to lay hold on you;
for you have concealed your face from us,
and have melted us away by the power of our iniquities.[f]
8 But now, O Yahweh, you are our Father;
we are the clay, and you our potter;
and we are all the work of your hand.[g]
9 Be not angry beyond measure, O Yahweh,
nor remember iniquity forever.
See, look, we pray, we are all your people.
10 Your holy cities have become a wilderness;
Zion has become a wilderness,
Jerusalem a desolation.

11 The house of our holiness and our splendor,
in which our fathers gave you praise,
is burned up with fire,
and every precious thing of ours is a ruin.
12 After all this, Yahweh, will you hold back?
Will you stay silent and punish us without limit?

Notes

- a (64:1) 64:1 is 63:19b in the Hebrew text, and Hebrew 64:1–11 is numbered 64:2–12 in English Bibles.
- b (64:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll lacks "that we did not look for" (literally "we did not wait for"), reading "awesome things we waited for."
- c (64:4) Paul echoes this verse in 1 Corinthians 2:9.
- d (64:5) The Hebrew of the last line is obscure. The Septuagint has "therefore we have erred."
- e (64:6) Hebrew beged ʻiddim, "a garment of menstruation," that is, ritually unclean (Leviticus 15:19–24).
- f (64:7) Hebrew wattemugenu, "and made us melt"; the Septuagint and other ancient versions are reported to read "and delivered us."
- g (64:8) Compare 29:16; 45:9; Jeremiah 18:6; Romans 9:20–21.

Chapter 65

1 "I was ready to be inquired of by those who asked not;
I was ready to be found by those who sought me not;
'Behold me, behold me,' I said
to a nation not called by my name.[a]
2 All day long I have held out my hands
to a rebellious people,
who walk a path that is not good,
following their own plans;[b]
3 a people who provoke me
to my face continually,
sacrificing in the gardens
and burning incense upon the bricks;[c]
4 who sit among the tombs
and spend the night in secret places;[d]
who eat the flesh of swine,
and broth of foul things is in their vessels;

5 who say, ‘Stand back by yourself,
draw not near to me, for I am holier than you.’[e]
Such men are smoke in my nose,
a fire burning all day long.
6 See, it stands written before me:
I will not be still unless I have paid back;
yes, I will pay back into their lap
7 for your sins and the sins of your ancestors together,
says Yahweh,
because they burned incense on the mountains
and insulted me on the hills;
I will pour into their laps
the full payment for their earlier deeds.”
8 This is what Yahweh says:
“When juice is still found in a cluster of grapes,
and someone says, ‘Do not spoil it,
because there is something good in it,’
I will do the same for the sake of my servants
and not destroy everyone.
9 I will bring forth offspring from Jacob,
and from Judah heirs of my mountains;
my chosen ones shall inherit it,
and my servants shall dwell there.
10 And Sharon shall be a fold for sheep,
and the Valley of Achor a place where cattle lie down,[f]
for my people that have sought me.
11 “But you who forsake Yahweh,
who forget my holy mountain,
who set a table for Gad,
and fill bowls of mixed wine for Meni,[g]
12 I will destine you to the sword,
and you shall all kneel for the slaughter;
for I called, and you gave no answer;
I spoke, and you would not hear;

you did evil in my sight
and chose that in which I had no pleasure."
13 Therefore thus says the Lord Yahweh:
"See, my servants shall eat,
but you shall be hungry;
see, my servants shall drink,
but you shall be thirsty;
see, my servants shall rejoice,
but you shall be put to shame;
14 see, my servants shall shout from a glad heart,
and you shall cry out from a sore heart,
and howl from a shattered spirit.
15 Your name you shall leave behind as an oath for my chosen:
and the Lord Yahweh shall slay you;
but his servants he will call by another name,
16 so that whoever asks for a blessing in the land
will ask the God of truth[h] for it,
and whoever takes an oath in the land
will swear by the God of truth;
for the earlier troubles will be forgotten
and hidden from my sight.
17 "For see, I create new heavens
and a new earth,[i]
and the former things shall not be remembered,
nor come into mind.
18 But be glad and rejoice forever
in that which I create;
for see, I create Jerusalem a rejoicing,
and her people a gladness.
19 And I will exult over Jerusalem
and take joy in my people;
never again shall there be heard in her
the voice of weeping and the voice of crying.[j]
20 There shall be from there no more
a suckling of few days,

nor an old man who does not fill out his days;
for he who dies at a hundred years shall die a youth,
and he who falls short of a hundred shall be held accursed.[k]
21 They shall build houses and dwell in them;
they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit.
22 They shall not build and another dwell;
they shall not plant and another eat;
for as the days of a tree shall be the days of my people,
and my chosen shall long enjoy the work of their hands.
23 They shall not toil in vain,
nor bear children for sudden terror;
for they are the offspring of the blessed of Yahweh,
and their descendants with them.
24 Before they call I will answer;
while they are yet speaking I will hear.
25 Wolf and lamb will feed together;
the lion will eat straw like an ox;
and the serpent's food will be dust.
They will do no harm or damage
on all my holy mountain," says Yahweh.[l]

Notes

- a (65:1) Paul quotes verses 1–2 from the Septuagint in Romans 10:20–21, applying verse 1 to the Gentiles and verse 2 to Israel.
- b (65:2) Or "their own thoughts."
- c (65:3) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads obscurely "and they suck (?) hands upon the stones."
- d (65:4) Or "among the rock tombs."
- e (65:5) Hebrew "for I am holy to you," or, with different vowels, "for I would make you holy," that is, pass holiness on to you.
- f (65:10) Achor, "trouble"; compare Joshua 7:24–26; Hosea 2:15.
- g (65:11) Gad and Meni are pagan gods of luck, "Fortune" and "Destiny"; meni puns on manah, "destine," in verse 12. The Septuagint has "a table for the devil … a drink offering to Fortune."
- h (65:16) Hebrew Elohe amen, "the God of truth," "the faithful God." Compare 2 Corinthians 1:20; Revelation 3:14.
- i (65:17) Compare 66:22; 2 Peter 3:13; Revelation 21:1.
- j (65:19) Compare Revelation 21:4.

- k (65:20) Or “the youth shall die a hundred years old, and the sinner shall be accursed at a hundred years old”; either way, a life of a hundred years shall be thought short.
- l (65:25) Compare 11:6–9; Genesis 3:14.

Chapter 66

1 Thus says Yahweh:
“The heavens are my throne,
and the earth the stool for my feet;
what manner of house would you build me,
and what manner of place for my rest?[a]
2 My hand made all these things,
and that is how they all came into being,
declares Yahweh.
But this is the person I will look at:
the one who is humble, broken in spirit,
and trembles at my word.
3 “Whoever slaughters an ox is like someone who kills a person;
whoever sacrifices a lamb is like someone who breaks a dog’s neck;
whoever presents a grain offering is like someone presenting pig’s blood;
whoever burns incense as a memorial portion is like someone who praises an idol.[b]
These people have chosen their own ways,
and their souls enjoy their detestable practices;
4 so I also will choose harsh treatment for them,
and bring upon them what they dread,
for I called, and none would answer;
I spoke, and they would not hear;
they did evil in my sight,
and chose that in which I had no pleasure.”
5 Hear the word of Yahweh,
you who tremble at his word:
“Your kinsmen that hate you,
that thrust you away because of my name,
have said, ‘Let Yahweh show his glory,

that we may see your joy';
yet they themselves shall be ashamed.
6 Hark, a tumult from the city!
Hark, from the temple!
It is the voice of Yahweh,
rendering recompense to his enemies!
7 "Before she writhed in travail
she brought forth;
before the pangs could seize her
she was delivered of a boy.[c]
8 Who has heard such a thing?
Who has seen such things?
Shall a land be born in one day?
Shall a nation be brought forth in a moment?
For as soon as Zion was in labor
she brought forth her sons.
9 Would I bring a baby to the moment of birth and not deliver it?"
says Yahweh;
"would I, the one who delivers, close the womb?"
says your God.
10 "Be joyful with Jerusalem, and exult over her,
all you that love her;
be glad with her in gladness,
all you that grieved for her;
11 so that you may suck and be filled
at the breast of her comforting;
so that you may drain it and take pleasure
in the fullness of her glory."[d]
12 For thus says Yahweh:
"Behold, I will make peace flow to her as a river,
and the riches of the nations as a stream in flood;
and you shall be nursed, and borne upon the side,
and dandled upon the knees.

13 As one whom his mother comforts,
so will I comfort you;
you shall be comforted in Jerusalem.
14 When you see this, your heart will celebrate;
your bones will sprout like fresh grass;
Yahweh's power will be seen in his servants,
and his fury in his enemies.
15 "Look, Yahweh is coming with fire,
and his chariots are like a whirlwind,
to repay his anger with fury
and his rebuke with blazing flames.
16 For Yahweh will execute judgment on all people
with fire and with his sword;
and those killed by Yahweh will be many.[e]
17 "People who consecrate and cleanse themselves to enter the gardens,
following someone in the middle,[f]
and who eat pork, detestable creatures and mice,
will all meet their end together, declares Yahweh.
18 "And I, knowing their deeds and their thoughts,[g]
am coming to gather all the nations and the tongues,
and they shall come and behold my glory,
19 and I will place a sign among them.
And I will send those of them who escape to the nations,
to Tarshish, Pul, and Lud, the archers,[h]
to Tubal and Javan, to the distant coastlands
which have never heard report of me nor seen my glory;
and they shall declare my glory among the nations.
20 They will bring all your relatives from every nation
as an offering to Yahweh,
on horses, in chariots and wagons,
on mules and on camels,
to my holy mountain Jerusalem, says Yahweh,
as the Israelites bring grain offerings
in clean containers to Yahweh's house.

21 And of them too I will take some
to be priests, to be Levites, says Yahweh.[i]
22 "As the new heavens and the new earth
that I am making
will stand before me, declares Yahweh,
so your descendants and your name will stand.
23 And it shall be that month by month at the new moon,
and week by week on the Sabbath,
all flesh shall come to bow down before me,
declares Yahweh.
24 "And they shall go out and look
on the corpses of the men
who have rebelled against me;
for their worm shall not die,
and their fire shall not be quenched,
and they shall be an abhorrence to all flesh."[j]

Notes

- a (66:1) Stephen quotes verses 1–2a in Acts 7:49–50; compare 1 Kings 8:27.
- b (66:3) Or "like one who worships wickedness" (aven, "trouble," "idolatry").
- c (66:7) Compare Revelation 12:5.
- d (66:11) Or "from the abundance of her glory"; the meaning of Hebrew ziz is uncertain.
- e (66:16) The Great Isaiah Scroll reads "For with fire Yahweh shall come to judge ... all flesh," lacking the second "Yahweh."
- f (66:17) So the read form of the Hebrew, "one (feminine)," perhaps a priestess or goddess; the written form has the masculine. The Septuagint has "and eat swine's flesh in the porches." For "shall come to an end together, declares Yahweh," the Great Isaiah Scroll reads "together, says Yahweh."
- g (66:18) The Hebrew is abrupt, "And I, their works and their thoughts ..."; "knowing" is supplied.
- h (66:19) Hebrew "who draw the bow." For "Pul" the Septuagint has "Phud" (Put), and in place of "who draw the bow" it has "Meshech."
- i (66:21) The Great Isaiah Scroll adds "to me" ("for priests, for Levites to me").
- j (66:24) Jesus applies the last lines to Gehenna in Mark 9:48. In synagogue reading verse 23 is repeated after verse 24, so that the book does not end on a note of judgment; the Great Isaiah Scroll and 1QIsa-b end with verse 24 as in the Masoretic Text.

Jeremiah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The words of Jeremiah[a] the son of Hilkiah,[b] of the priests who were
in Anathoth[c] in the land of Benjamin, 2 to whom the word of Yahweh
came in the days of Josiah[d] the son of Amon, king of Judah, in the
thirteenth year of his reign.[e] 3 It came also in the days of Jehoiakim[f]
the son of Josiah, king of Judah, until the end of the eleventh year of
Zedekiah[g] the son of Josiah, king of Judah, until the carrying away of
Jerusalem into exile in the fifth month (in July–August).[h]
4 Now the word of Yahweh came to me, saying,
5 "Before I formed you inside your mother I already knew you,
and before your birth I had set you apart;
I have appointed you as a prophet over the nations."
6 Then I said, "Ah, Lord Yahweh![i] See, I do not know how to speak,
for I am a youth."
7 Yet Yahweh answered me,
"Say not, 'A youth am I';
for wherever I send you, there you must go,
and whatever I bid you, that you must speak.
8 Be not afraid of their faces,
for with you am I to deliver you," declares Yahweh.
9 Then Yahweh put forth his hand and touched my mouth, and
Yahweh said to me,
"See, I have put my words in your mouth.
10 See, I have set you this day over the nations and over the kingdoms,
to pluck up and to pull down,
to destroy and to overthrow,
to build and to plant."
11 The word of Yahweh came to me: "What are you looking at,
Jeremiah?" I answered, "I see a branch of an almond tree."[j] 12 Then

Yahweh said to me, “You have seen well, for I am watching[k] over my word to perform it.”
13 And the word of Yahweh came to me a second time, saying, “What do you see?” And I said, “A boiling pot I see, and its face is turned away from the north.”[l] 14 Then Yahweh said to me, “Out of the north disaster shall break loose upon all the inhabitants of the land. 15 For look, I am summoning all the families of the northern kingdoms,” declares Yahweh. “They will come, and each ruler will set up his throne at the entrance of Jerusalem’s gates, facing all its surrounding walls and all the towns of Judah. 16 And I will speak my judgments against them for all their evil, in that they have forsaken me and have burned incense[m] to other gods and bowed down to the works of their own hands. 17 But you, gird up your loins; arise and speak to them all that I command you. Be not dismayed before them, lest I dismay you before them. 18 And I—see, I have made you this day a fortified city, and a pillar of iron, and walls of bronze against the whole land, against the kings of Judah, against its princes, against its priests, and against the people of the land. 19 And they will fight against you, but they shall not prevail against you, for with you am I,” declares Yahweh, “to deliver you.”

Notes

- a (1:1) Jeremiah (Hebrew Yirmeyahu) probably means “Yahweh exalts” or “Yahweh founds”; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (1:1) Hilkiah means “My portion is Yahweh.”
- c (1:1) Anathoth, a priestly town about 3 miles (5 kilometers) northeast of Jerusalem (Joshua 21:18); Abiathar the priest was banished there (1 Kings 2:26).
- d (1:2) Josiah probably means “Yahweh supports” or “Yahweh heals”; uncertain.
- e (1:2) That is, about 627 B.C.
- f (1:3) Jehoiakim means “Yahweh raises up.”
- g (1:3) Zedekiah means “Yahweh is righteousness.”
- h (1:3) Hebrew “the fifth month,” Av, counted from the spring new year; that is, in 586 B.C. (see 52:12). The modern equivalent is approximate, since the Hebrew year was lunar.
- i (1:6) Hebrew Adonai Yahweh. The Septuagint reads “O Lord, you that are supreme Lord” (Brenton, modernized).

- j (1:11) Hebrew shaqed, "almond tree," sounds like shoqed, "watching" (verse 12). The almond was called "the watcher" or "the wakeful tree" because it blossoms first in the year.
- k (1:12) Hebrew shoqed; see the note at verse 11. The Septuagint reads "I have watched over my words to perform them" (Brenton).
- l (1:13) Or "tilted away from the north," that is, about to pour out toward the south.
- m (1:16) Or "made offerings go up in smoke."

Chapter 2

1 And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying,[a]
2 "Go and cry in the ears of Jerusalem, saying, 'Thus says Yahweh:
I remember for you the devotion[b] of your youth,
the love of your bridal days,
your going after me in the wilderness,
in a land not sown.
3 Holy was Israel to Yahweh,
the firstfruits of his harvest;
all who devoured him were held guilty;
disaster came upon them,' declares Yahweh."
4 Listen to Yahweh's word, house of Jacob,
and all the families of the house of Israel.
5 Thus has Yahweh spoken:
"What fault did your forefathers detect in me,
that far from me they strayed,
pursued what is vapor,[c] and turned to vapor?
6 They did not ask, 'Where is Yahweh,
the one who rescued us from Egypt
and guided us across the wilderness,
across a land of deserts and pits,
a land of dry heat and pitch dark,
a land where nobody travels
and nobody makes a home?'
7 I brought you to a fertile land,[d]
to enjoy its fruit and its goodness;
but when you arrived you made my land unclean,
and turned my inheritance into something detestable.

8 The priests never asked, ‘Where is Yahweh?’
Those who wield the law knew me not;
the shepherds[e] rebelled against me;
the prophets spoke by Baal[f]
and pursued what brings no gain.
9 “So I will bring charges against you again,” declares Yahweh,
“and I will bring charges against your grandchildren.
10 For cross over to the coasts of Kittim[g] and see,
and send to Kedar[h] and consider diligently,
and see if there has been such a thing as this.
11 Has a nation exchanged its gods,
even though they are no gods?
Yet my people have exchanged their glory[i]
for that which does not profit.
12 Be appalled, O heavens, at this;
shudder, be utterly desolate,” declares Yahweh,
13 “for two evils my people have committed:
me they have forsaken,
the fountain of living waters,
to hew out for themselves cisterns,
broken cisterns, which cannot hold water.
14 “Is Israel a bondman? Or one born in the household?
Why then has he become spoil?
15 Over him the young lions have roared;
they have lifted up their voice.
They have made his land a waste;
his cities are burned, without inhabitant.
16 Also the men of Noph[j] and Tahpanhes[k]
have grazed[l] the crown of your head.
17 Is not this your own doing,
in abandoning Yahweh your God
when he guided you on the road?
18 And now, what have you to do with the road to Egypt,
to drink the waters of the Shihor?[m]

Or what have you to do with the road to Assyria,
to drink the waters of the River?[n]
19 Your own wickedness will punish you,
and your unfaithfulness will condemn you.
Understand, then, and recognize how bad and bitter it is
for you to abandon Yahweh your God
and to have no fear of me,"
declares the Lord Yahweh of Armies.[o]
20 "For long ago you broke your yoke
and tore off your bonds,
and you said, 'I will not serve.'
For on every high hill
and under every green tree
you sprawled as a harlot.
21 Yet I had planted you a choice vine,
wholly of true seed.
How then have you turned yourself into
the degenerate shoots of a foreign vine before me?
22 For though you wash with lye
and use for yourself much soap,
the stain of your iniquity is before me,"
declares the Lord Yahweh.
23 "How can you say, 'I am not defiled;
after the Baals I have not gone'?
See your way in the valley;[p]
know what you have done—
a swift young she-camel
running crisscross on her paths,
24 a wild donkey used to the wilderness,
in the lust of her soul sniffing the wind!
In her heat who can turn her back?
All who seek her need not weary themselves;
in her month they will find her.
25 Keep your feet from going bare
and your throat from going dry.

But you answered, ‘It’s no use!
I love foreign gods,
and I will chase after them.’
26 “As a thief is ashamed when caught,
so the house of Israel is ashamed—
the people, their kings, their officials,
their priests and their prophets—
27 They say to a tree, ‘You are my father,’
and to a rock, ‘You are the one who bore me.’
They have faced away from me and shown me their backs;
but when they are in trouble they cry,
‘Come and save us!’
28 Where then are those gods you made for yourself?
Up with them, if they can rescue you
when trouble comes;
for your gods have grown as many
as your towns, O Judah.[q]
29 “Why do you contend with me?
All of you have transgressed against me,” declares Yahweh.
30 “To no purpose I smote your sons;
correction they would not receive.
Your sword consumed your prophets
like a ravaging lion.
31 O generation, you—see the word of Yahweh!
Have I been a wilderness to Israel,
or a land of thick darkness?[r]
Why do my people say, ‘We roam free;
we will come to you no more’?
32 Can a virgin forget her ornaments,
or a bride her sash?
Yet my people have forgotten me
days without number.
33 “How skillfully you pursue love!
Even wicked women
have learned from your example.

34 Even in your skirts is found
the blood of the guiltless poor;
not as housebreakers did you find them.[s]
Yet in spite of all this
35 you say, 'I am innocent;
certainly his anger has turned away from me.'
But look, I will put you on trial
for saying, 'I have not sinned.'
36 How lightly you go about,
changing your way!
By Egypt also you shall be put to shame,
as you were put to shame by Assyria.
37 From there also you shall go out
with your hands upon your head;[t]
for Yahweh has rejected those in whom you trust,
and you shall not prosper through them.

Notes

- a (2:1) The Septuagint lacks verse 1 and the opening words of verse 2, reading simply "And he said, Thus says the Lord" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (2:2) Hebrew ḥesed, loyal love or covenant faithfulness.
- c (2:5) Hebrew hevel, "vapor" or "breath," often used of idols; the verb that follows plays on it.
- d (2:7) Hebrew "a land of the Carmel," that is, a garden land.
- e (2:8) That is, the rulers.
- f (2:8) Baal, "lord" or "master," the Canaanite storm god.
- g (2:10) Kittim, originally Kition on Cyprus; here the western islands and coastlands generally.
- h (2:10) Kedar, a tribe of the Arabian desert to the east; so the verse means "search from west to east."
- i (2:11) An ancient Jewish tradition counts this as one of the "corrections of the scribes," the original reading being "my glory."
- j (2:16) Noph is Memphis, the ancient capital of Lower Egypt.
- k (2:16) Tahpanhes, an Egyptian frontier fortress in the eastern Nile Delta; see 43:7–9.
- l (2:16) Or "have shaved" or "have broken"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- m (2:18) Shihor, a branch of the Nile, or the Nile itself; the Septuagint has "Geon" (Brenton).
- n (2:18) That is, the Euphrates.

- o (2:19) Hebrew Adonai YHWH Tseva'ot. "Yahweh of Armies" (traditionally "the LORD of hosts") presents God as commander of the heavenly armies and of Israel's forces. This title occurs more than 80 times in the Hebrew of Jeremiah; the Septuagint very often lacks "of Armies," and here reads "says the Lord your God" (Brenton, modernized).
- p (2:23) Probably the Valley of Ben-hinnom (see 7:31); the Septuagint reads "the burial-ground" (Brenton).
- q (2:28) The Septuagint adds, "and according to the number of the streets of Jerusalem they sacrificed to Baal" (Brenton); compare 11:13.
- r (2:31) Or "a land of deep gloom," Hebrew ma'pelyah, found only here.
- s (2:34) That is, they were not burglars caught in the act, whom it would have been lawful to kill (Exodus 22:2).
- t (2:37) A gesture of grief and shame (2 Samuel 13:19).

Chapter 3

1 "If a husband divorces his wife,[a]
and she goes away from him
to become another man's wife,
may the first husband take her back?
Would the land not be thoroughly defiled by that?
You, however, have prostituted yourself with many lovers;
and now you want to return to me?" declares Yahweh.
2 "Look up at the barren hills[b] and see:
where have you not been ravished?
You waited for lovers beside the roads
like a nomad[c] in the desert,
and you defiled the land
with your prostitution and your evil.
3 So the showers were held back,
and the late rains[d] did not come.
Yet you had the brazen look of a prostitute;
you refused to feel shame.
4 Have you not just now cried to me,
'My father, the companion of my youth are you!
5 Will he keep his anger forever?
Will he guard it to the end?'

See, so you have spoken,
yet you have done all the evil that you could."
6 And Yahweh said to me in the days of Josiah the king, "Have
you seen what she did, faithless Israel?[e] She went up on every high
mountain and under every green tree, and there played the harlot.
7 And I said, after she had done all these things, 'To me she will
return'; but she did not return. And her treacherous sister Judah saw
it. 8 And I saw that, because faithless Israel had committed adultery,
I had dismissed her and handed her a writ of divorce; yet Judah her
treacherous sister felt no fear, but went off and played the harlot as
well. 9 And through the lightness of her harlotry she polluted the
land, committing adultery with stone and with tree. 10 Even so, her
unfaithful sister Judah did not come back to me wholeheartedly, but
only in pretense," declares Yahweh.
11 Then Yahweh said to me, "Faithless Israel has shown herself more
righteous than treacherous Judah.
12 Go and announce this message to the north:
'Come back, unfaithful Israel,' declares Yahweh;
'I will not look on you with anger,
because I am loyal,' declares Yahweh;
'I will not stay angry forever.
13 Only acknowledge your iniquity,
that against Yahweh your God you have transgressed,
and have scattered your ways to strangers
under every green tree,
and my voice you have not obeyed,' declares Yahweh.
14 Return, O faithless children," declares Yahweh, "for I am your
husband;[f] and I will take you, one from a city and two from a clan,
and I will bring you to Zion.
15 And I will grant you shepherds suited to my heart, who will pasture
you with knowledge and insight.
16 And when you have increased and borne fruit in the land, in
those days," declares Yahweh, "men will speak no more of 'the ark
of Yahweh's covenant.' It will not rise in the mind; they will neither
recall it nor miss it, nor will another be made.

17 At that time they shall call Jerusalem ‘The Throne of Yahweh,’
and all the nations shall be gathered to it, to the name of Yahweh,
to Jerusalem; and they shall walk no more after the stubbornness of
their evil heart.
18 In those days Judah’s house shall walk alongside Israel’s house, and
together they shall come out of the northern land into the land that
I bestowed on your fathers as a possession.
19 “And I had thought,
‘How gladly would I place you with my sons,
and grant you a delightful land,
the loveliest inheritance among the nations!’
And I thought you would call me ‘My Father,’
and never turn back from following me.
20 Surely, as a wife treacherously leaves her companion,
so have you dealt treacherously with me, O house of Israel,”
declares Yahweh.
21 On the bare heights a cry is heard,
Israel’s sons weeping and entreating,
for they have twisted their way;
Yahweh their God they have forgotten.
22 “Return, O faithless sons;
I will heal your faithlessness.”
“See, we have come to you,
for you are Yahweh our God.
23 Truly, a delusion are the hills,
the tumult on the mountains;
truly in Yahweh our God
is the salvation of Israel.
24 But the shameful thing[g] has devoured
the labor of our fathers from our youth,
their flocks and their herds,
their sons and their daughters.
25 Let us lie down in our shame,
and let our disgrace cover us;
for against Yahweh our God we have sinned,

we and our fathers,
from our youth even to this day,
and we have not obeyed the voice of Yahweh our God."

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew begins "Saying," perhaps a fragment of a lost introduction. The law of Deuteronomy 24:1–4 forbids a man to take back a divorced wife who has married another.
- b (3:2) Hebrew shefayim, bare hills, places of pagan worship; also in verse 21.
- c (3:2) That is, a desert nomad lying in wait to rob travelers.
- d (3:3) Hebrew malqosh, the spring rain of March–April that ripens the grain.
- e (3:6) Hebrew meshuvah yisraʾel, literally "turning-away Israel," the northern kingdom, exiled by Assyria in 722 B.C. Jeremiah plays repeatedly on shuv, "turn, return" (verses 12, 14, 22).
- f (3:14) Or "I am your master"; Hebrew baʿalti, a play on Baal.
- g (3:24) Hebrew habbosheth, "the Shame," a contemptuous substitute for Baal (compare 11:13).

Chapter 4

1 "If you return, O Israel," declares Yahweh,
"to me you should return.
If you put away your abominations from before me,
and do not waver,
2 and if you swear, 'As surely as Yahweh lives,'
sincerely, justly and rightly,
then the nations will invoke blessings by him,
and will boast in him."
3 For thus says Yahweh to the men of Judah and to Jerusalem:
"Break up your fallow ground,
and do not sow among thorns.
4 Dedicate yourselves to Yahweh;
cut away the foreskins of your hearts,
people of Judah and residents of Jerusalem,
or my anger will blaze out like fire
and burn so that no one can put it out,
because of your evil actions."
5 Announce this in Judah and proclaim it in Jerusalem:
"Sound the ram's horn throughout the land;

shout out loud and say,
'Gather together, and let us flee
to the fortified cities!'
6 Raise a signal toward Zion;
flee for safety; do not stand still,
for I am bringing disaster from the north,
and a great destruction.
7 Up from his thicket the lion has gone,
the ravager of nations is on the march;
out from his place he has come
to turn your land into a waste;
your towns shall lie in ruins, empty of people.
8 For this gird on sackcloth;
lament and wail,
for the fierce anger of Yahweh
has not turned back from us."
9 "And it shall come to pass in that day," declares Yahweh, "that the heart of the king shall fail, and the heart of the princes; the priests shall be appalled, and the prophets astounded."
10 Then I said, "Oh, Lord Yahweh! You have completely tricked this people and Jerusalem by promising, 'You will have peace,' while the sword is at our throats."[a]
11 At that time it shall be said to this people and to Jerusalem,
"A scorching wind from the bare heights in the wilderness
comes toward the daughter of my people,
not to winnow nor to cleanse,
12 a wind too strong for these comes at my bidding.
Now I also will speak judgments against them."
13 See, like clouds he comes up,
and like the whirlwind his chariots;
swifter than eagles are his horses.
Woe to us, for we are ruined!
14 Wash the evil out of your heart, Jerusalem,
so that you can be saved.

How long will your harmful thoughts
stay inside you?
15 For hark, one tells it from Dan,
and announces evil from the hills of Ephraim:[b]
16 "Warn the nations, see!
Proclaim against Jerusalem:
besiegers[c] come from a distant land;
they lift their voice against the cities of Judah.
17 Like keepers of a field they are against her round about,
because against me she has rebelled," declares Yahweh.
18 "Your way and your deeds
have brought these things upon you.
This is your evil; how bitter it is!
How it reaches to your heart!"
19 My bowels, my bowels![d] I writhe in pain!
O the walls of my heart!
My heart moans within me;
I cannot keep silent,
for the sound of the ram's horn you have heard, O my soul,
the alarm of war.
20 One disaster follows another,
for the whole land is ruined.
In an instant my tents are destroyed,
my tent curtains in a moment.
21 How long must I see the signal
and hear the sound of the ram's horn?
22 "For my people are foolish;
me they do not know.
Senseless children are they,
and they have no understanding.
Wise are they to do evil,
but to do good they know not."
23 I looked on the earth, and see, it was formless and void;[e]
and to the heavens, and their light was gone.

24 I looked on the mountains, and see, they were quaking,
and all the hills moved to and fro.
25 I looked, and see, there was no man,
and all the birds of the heavens had fled.
26 I looked, and see, the garden land[f] was a wilderness,
and all its cities were broken down
before Yahweh, before his fierce anger.
27 For thus says Yahweh:
"A desolation shall the whole land be;
yet a full end I will not make.
28 Because of this the land shall mourn,
and the sky above grow black;
for I have spoken it, I have determined it;
I will not relent, nor will I draw back."
29 At the noise of horseman and archer
every city flees;
they go into thickets;
they climb among the rocks;
every city is forsaken,
and no man dwells in them.
30 And you, devastated one, what are you doing?
You dress in scarlet,
put on gold jewelry,
and paint your eyes with makeup,[g]
but you beautify yourself for nothing.
Your lovers reject you;
they are trying to kill you.
31 For I hear a cry as of one in travail,
distress as of one bringing forth her firstborn,
the cry of Zion's daughter, panting,
spreading her hands:
"Ah me! My life is failing
before the slayers."

Notes

- a (4:10) The Septuagint reads “And I said, O sovereign Lord, truly you have greatly deceived this people” (Brenton, modernized); some ancient witnesses read “And they shall say,” making the words those of the priests and prophets.
- b (4:15) Dan is at the far north of the land; the hill country of Ephraim lies just north of Jerusalem: the invader draws nearer.
- c (4:16) Hebrew notsrim, “watchers” or “besiegers”; a slight change of vowels gives “enemies.”
- d (4:19) Hebrew “My inward parts,” regarded as the seat of the emotions.
- e (4:23) Hebrew tohu wavohu, the words of Genesis 1:2.
- f (4:26) Hebrew “the Carmel,” the fruitful land.
- g (4:30) Hebrew puk, a black eye-paint made of antimony or galena.

Chapter 5

1 Run to and fro through Jerusalem’s streets,
and look, I pray, and take note;
search through her open squares,
whether you can find a man,
whether there is one who does justice,
who seeks faithfulness,
that I may pardon her.
2 Though they say, “As Yahweh lives,”
yet falsely do they swear.
3 O Yahweh, do not your eyes look for faithfulness?
You struck them, but they felt no grief;
you consumed them, but they refused to accept correction.
Harder than rock they made their faces;
they refused to turn back.
4 Then I said, “Surely these are only the poor;
they act foolishly,
for they know not Yahweh’s way,
the judgment of their God.
5 I will get me to the great ones
and speak with them,
for they know Yahweh’s way,
the judgment of their God.”
But these too had all alike shattered the yoke;
they had snapped the bonds.

6 Therefore a lion from the forest shall slay them;
a wolf of the desert plains shall ravage them;
a leopard keeps watch over their towns;
whoever goes out of them shall be torn in pieces,
because their transgressions are many,
mighty their acts of turning away.
7 "How can I forgive you for this?
Your children have abandoned me
and sworn by gods that are not gods.
I fed them until they were full, yet they committed adultery
and crowded into the houses of prostitutes.
8 Well-fed stallions, lusty,[a] they have become;
each neighs after his neighbor's wife.
9 Shall I not punish them for these things?" declares Yahweh;
"and on a nation such as this
shall my soul not take vengeance?
10 "Go up among her terraced vines and ruin them,
yet do not finish her off;
lop away her tendrils,
for they belong not to Yahweh.
11 For utterly faithless to me have they been,
the house of Israel and the house of Judah," declares Yahweh.
12 They have lied about Yahweh
and said, "It is not he;[b]
no harm shall come upon us,
nor shall we see sword or famine.
13 The prophets shall turn to wind;
the word is not in them.
So be it done to them!"
14 Therefore this is what Yahweh, the God of Armies, says:
"Because you have said this,
look, I am turning my words in your mouth into fire,
and this people into wood that it will burn up.
15 Look, I am bringing a nation against you from far away, house of Israel," declares Yahweh.

“It is a lasting nation,
an ancient nation,
whose language you do not know,
and you cannot understand what they say.
16 Their quiver is a gaping tomb;
warriors, every one of them.[c]
17 Your crops and your bread they will devour;
your sons and daughters they will devour;
your sheep and cattle they will devour;
your vine and fig they will devour;
the walled towns you rely on
they will batter down with the sword.
18 “Yet even in those days,” declares Yahweh, “I will not make a full end of you. 19 And when they ask, ‘Why has Yahweh our God treated us like this?’ answer them, ‘You abandoned me and served foreign gods in your own land, so you will serve strangers in a land that does not belong to you.’
20 “Announce this among Jacob’s house;
make it heard in Judah, and say:
21 ‘Hear now this, O foolish and heartless people,
who have eyes, yet see not,
who have ears, yet hear not.
22 Do you not fear me?’ declares Yahweh.
‘Will you not tremble in my presence?
I made the sand the boundary for the sea,
an eternal limit it cannot cross;
23 But this people has a heart both obstinate and defiant;
they have veered off and departed.
24 Never do they say within themselves,
“Come, let us fear Yahweh our God,
who sends rain at its proper time,
the early and the later showers,[d]
who guards for our sake
the fixed weeks of reaping.”

25 Your iniquities have turned these away,
and your sins have withheld the good from you.
26 For among my people are found wicked men;
they watch like fowlers who crouch;[e]
they set a trap;
men they catch.
27 Like a cage full of birds,
so are their houses full of deceit;
therefore they have become great and grown rich.
28 They have grown fat and sleek;
they also overpass in deeds of evil;
they plead not the cause, the cause of the fatherless, that they may prosper,
and the right of the needy they do not defend.
29 Shall I not punish them for these things?' declares Yahweh;
'and on a nation such as this
shall my soul not take vengeance?'
30 "A horrible and appalling thing
has come to pass in the land:
31 the prophets prophesy falsely,
and the priests rule at their direction;[f]
and my people love it so.
But what will you do at its end?"

Notes

- a (5:8) Hebrew meshakim, of uncertain meaning; perhaps "well-equipped" or "lusty."
- b (5:12) Or "He will do nothing."
- c (5:16) The Septuagint lacks "Their quiver is like an open grave," reading only "They are all mighty men" (Brenton, modernized).
- d (5:24) Hebrew yoreh, the autumn rain (October–November), and malqosh, the spring rain (March–April).
- e (5:26) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- f (5:31) Or "rule by their own authority"; Hebrew "by their hands."

Chapter 6

1 “Flee for safety, O sons of Benjamin,
out of the midst of Jerusalem!
In Tekoa[a] blow the ram’s horn,
and over Beth-haccherem[b] raise a signal,
for disaster looms out of the north,
and great destruction.
2 The comely and delicate one,
the daughter of Zion, I will destroy.[c]
3 Herdsmen with their flocks will march on her;
round about her they will pitch their tents;
each will crop his own patch.
4 ‘Consecrate war against her![d]
Arise, and let us go up at noon!
Woe to us, for the day declines,
for the shadows of evening stretch out!
5 Arise, and let us go up by night
and destroy her palaces!’”
6 For this is what Yahweh of Armies says:
“Chop down her trees
and heap up a siege ramp to attack Jerusalem.
This city is due for punishment;
every part of it is full of oppression.
7 As a cistern keeps its water cool,
so she keeps her evil cool and fresh;
outrage and havoc echo in her;
sickness and blows are before my face continually.
8 Be warned, O Jerusalem,
lest my soul be torn from you,
lest I make you a desolation,
a land uninhabited.”
9 This is what Yahweh of Armies says:
“They will pick the remnant of Israel
clean as a vine is picked;

like a grape harvester, run your hand
once more over the branches."
10 To whom shall I speak and give warning,
that they may hear?
See, their ear is uncircumcised,
and they cannot hearken.
See, the word of Yahweh has become to them a reproach;
they take no delight in it.
11 But I am full of the wrath of Yahweh;
I am weary of holding it in.
"Pour it out upon the child in the street,
and upon the gathering of young men together;
for husband with wife shall be taken,
the elder with him who is full of days.
12 Their houses shall pass over to others,
fields and wives together,
for I will stretch out my hand
against the inhabitants of the land," declares Yahweh.
13 "From the smallest to the biggest,
they are all greedy for dishonest profit;
prophets and priests alike
all practice deceit.
14 The fracture of my people they have patched up carelessly,
declaring, 'All is well, all is well,'
when nothing is well.
15 Did they feel shame for the loathsome things they did?
Not the least shame did they feel;
blushing they never learned.
So they will go down with the fallen;
when I call them to account they will be overthrown," Yahweh has said.
16 Thus has Yahweh spoken:
"Halt at the crossroads and look about;
inquire about the age-old tracks,
which is the good road, and travel on it,

and you will find repose for your souls.
But they replied, 'We refuse to travel it.'
17 I set watchmen over you, saying,
'Hearken to the sound of the ram's horn!'
But they said, 'We will not hearken.'
18 Therefore hear, O nations,
and know, O congregation, what is among them.[e]
19 Hear, O earth:
see, I am bringing disaster upon this people,
the fruit of their schemes,
because to my words they have not hearkened,
and my law—they have rejected it.
20 What use to me is incense arriving from Sheba,
or fragrant cane[f] from a far country?
Your whole offerings win no favor,
and your sacrifices give me no pleasure."
21 Therefore thus says Yahweh:
"See, I am laying before this people stumbling blocks,
and fathers and sons together shall stumble on them;
neighbor and friend shall perish."
22 Thus says Yahweh:
"See, a people comes from the land of the north;
a great nation is stirred up from the farthest parts of the earth.
23 They are armed with bows and spears;
they are cruel and have no mercy;
their noise is like the roaring sea;
they ride on horses,
lined up like warriors for battle
against you, daughter of Zion."
24 We have heard news of them,
and our hands have gone weak;
anguish has gripped us,
like the pain of a woman giving birth.
25 Venture not into the countryside,
nor travel the highway,

for the foe bears a sword;
dread surrounds on all sides.[g]
26 Daughter of my people, wrap yourself in sackcloth
and wallow in the ashes;
mourn as one mourns an only son,
a wailing most bitter,
for in an instant the ravager
will fall upon us.
27 "I have made you a tester of metals,[h] one who examines my people,
so that you can learn and test how they live.
28 They are all stubborn rebels,
going about with slander;
bronze and iron are they;
all of them deal corruptly.
29 The bellows blow fiercely;
the lead is consumed by the fire;[i]
in vain the refiner refines,
for the wicked are not drawn off.
30 Rejected silver they are called,
for Yahweh has rejected them."

Notes

- a (6:1) Tekoa, a town about 10 miles (16 kilometers) south of Jerusalem; its name sounds like the verb "blow" (tiqʿu).
- b (6:1) Beth-haccherem, "house of the vineyard," probably Ramat Rahel, between Jerusalem and Bethlehem.
- c (6:2) Or "The daughter of Zion is like a lovely pasture"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (6:4) Warfare was begun with religious rites.
- e (6:18) The Hebrew of this line is obscure.
- f (6:20) Hebrew qaneh, an aromatic reed, perhaps calamus.
- g (6:25) Hebrew magor missaviv, a favorite phrase of Jeremiah (20:3, 10; 46:5; 49:29).
- h (6:27) Or "a fortress"; Hebrew mivtsar, perhaps a scribal note. The image is of refining silver from ore, using lead to carry off impurities.
- i (6:29) So the Hebrew consonants read as "by fire the lead is consumed" (qere); the written text (ketiv) may be read "by their fire."

Chapter 7

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying:[a] 2 "Stand at
the gate of Yahweh's house and announce this message there: 'Listen
to Yahweh's word, all you people of Judah who go through these
gates to worship Yahweh. 3 This is what Yahweh of Armies, Israel's
God, says: Reform your conduct and your actions, and I will let you
dwell[b] in this place. 4 Put not your trust in lying words, saying, "The
temple of Yahweh, the temple of Yahweh, the temple of Yahweh are
these!"[c] 5 For only if you thoroughly reform your conduct and your
actions, if you deal out true justice between one man and another, 6 if
the sojourner, the fatherless, and the widow you do not oppress, and
innocent blood you do not shed in this place, and after other gods you
do not walk to your own harm, 7 then I will let you dwell in this place,
in the land that I gave to your fathers from of old even for evermore.
8 "'See, you are trusting in lying words that cannot profit. 9 Will you
steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, burn incense to Baal,
and walk after other gods whom you have not known, 10 and then
come and stand in front of me in this house that bears my name,
and say, "We are safe!"—only to carry on with all these detestable
practices? 11 Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den
of robbers in your eyes? I too, see, I have seen it,' declares Yahweh.
12 "'Go now to my place at Shiloh,[d] where I first gave my name a home,
and see what I did to it because of my people Israel's evil. 13 And now,
because you have done all these deeds,' declares Yahweh, 'and I spoke
to you, rising early and speaking, yet you did not hear, and I called
you, yet you did not answer, 14 then I will do to the house that bears
my name, the house you rely on, and to the place I gave to you and
your ancestors, what I did to Shiloh. 15 And I will cast you out from my
sight, as I cast out all your brothers, the whole offspring of Ephraim.'
16 "As for you, do not pray for this people, nor lift up a cry or a prayer
for them, nor intercede with me, for I will not hear you. 17 Do you
not see what they are doing in the cities of Judah and in the streets
of Jerusalem? 18 Sons collect sticks, fathers light the fire, and wives
work the dough, to bake cakes for the Queen of Heaven;[e] and they
pour libations to other gods to stir up my anger. 19 Is it I whom they

provoke?" declares Yahweh. "Is it not themselves, to the shame of their own faces?" 20 Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: "Look, my anger and fury will be poured out on this place, on humans and animals alike, on the field's trees and the land's crops; it will burn and will not be put out."

21 Thus says Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel: "Add your burnt offerings to your sacrifices, and eat flesh.[f] 22 For I did not speak to your fathers, nor command them, in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, concerning burnt offerings and sacrifices. 23 But this thing I commanded them: 'Obey my voice, and I will be your God, and you shall be my people; and walk in all the way that I command you, that it may be well with you.' 24 But they did not obey or incline their ear, but walked in their own counsels, in the stubbornness of their evil heart, and went backward and not forward. 25 From the day that your fathers came out of the land of Egypt until this day, I have sent to you all my servants the prophets, daily rising early and sending them. 26 Still they paid me no heed and bent no ear, but hardened their necks; they behaved worse than their ancestors.

27 "You will tell them all these words, but they will not listen to you; you will call out to them, but they will not answer you.[g] 28 And you shall say to them, 'This is the nation that did not obey the voice of Yahweh its God and did not accept correction; faithfulness has perished; it is cut off from their mouth.'

29 "Shear off your hair[h] and cast it away;
raise a lament on the bare heights,
for Yahweh has rejected and forsaken
the generation of his wrath."

30 "For Judah's sons have done what is evil before me," declares Yahweh. "Their loathsome idols they have placed in the house that bears my name, and so defiled it. 31 And they have built the high places of Topheth,[i] which is in the Valley of Ben-hinnom,[j] to burn their sons and their daughters in the fire, which I did not command, nor did it come into my mind. 32 Therefore, mark this: days are approaching," declares Yahweh, "when it will no longer be named Topheth or the Valley of Ben-hinnom, but the Valley of Killing; for they will bury in

Topheth till no space is left. 33 And the corpses of this people will be food for the birds of the heavens and for the beasts of the earth, and none will frighten them away. 34 And I will make to cease from the cities of Judah and from the streets of Jerusalem the voice of mirth and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride, for the land shall become a ruin.

Notes

- a (7:1) The Septuagint lacks verse 1 and the first half of verse 2; its text begins, "Hear the word of the Lord, all Judea" (Brenton). The same sermon is summarized in chapter 26.
- b (7:3) Or, with a change of vowels, "and I will dwell with you"; so also in verse 7.
- c (7:4) The Septuagint has the phrase twice: "It is the temple of the Lord, the temple of the Lord" (Brenton).
- d (7:12) Shiloh, where the tabernacle stood in the days of Eli (1 Samuel 1–4), was evidently destroyed after the Philistines captured the ark.
- e (7:18) Probably Ishtar (Astarte), the Mesopotamian goddess of love and war, worshiped as "Queen of Heaven"; see also 44:17–25. The Septuagint reads "to make cakes to the host of heaven" (Brenton).
- f (7:21) That is, eat even the burnt offerings, which were wholly burned; Yahweh no longer values them.
- g (7:27) The Septuagint lacks this verse except for its opening words: "Therefore you shall speak this word to them" (Brenton, modernized).
- h (7:29) Hebrew "your crown" (nezer), as a sign of mourning; the word is addressed to Jerusalem as a woman.
- i (7:31) Topheth, the place in the valley where children were burned as offerings; the name may mean "fireplace," with its vowels perhaps changed to suggest boshet, "shame."
- j (7:31) Ben-hinnom, "son of Hinnom," the valley south and west of Jerusalem; its later name Gehinnom gave rise to "Gehenna."

Chapter 8

1 "At that time," declares Yahweh, "people will take the bones of Judah's kings, officials, priests, prophets and Jerusalem's residents out of their graves 2 and spread them out under the sun, moon and all the stars of the sky, which they loved, served, followed, consulted and worshiped. Nobody will collect or bury them; they will lie like manure on the ground. 3 And death shall be chosen rather than life by all the remnant that remains of this evil family, in all the places where I have driven them," declares Yahweh of Armies.

4 “Tell them this also, ‘This is what Yahweh says:
Does a man who falls not get up?
Does one who strays not come back?
5 Why then has this people turned away,
Jerusalem, in a perpetual turning away?
They hold fast to deceit;
they refuse to return.
6 I listened and heard,
but they do not speak what is right;
no man repents of his evil,
saying, “What have I done?”
Each one turns to his own course,
like a horse plunging into battle.
7 Even the stork in the heavens
knows her appointed seasons,
and the turtledove, the swift,[a] and the crane
keep the time of their coming;
but my people know not
the judgment of Yahweh.
8 “‘How can you say, “We are wise,
and the law of Yahweh is with us”?
But see, the lying pen of the scribes
has made it into a lie.
9 The wise men are put to shame;
they are dismayed and caught;
see, they have rejected the word of Yahweh,
so what wisdom is in them?
10 So I will give their wives to other men
and their fields to new owners;
from the smallest to the greatest
they are all after dishonest gain;
prophets and priests alike
all practice deceit.

11 They have healed the wound of the daughter of my people lightly,
saying, “Peace, peace,”
when there is no peace.[b]
12 Were they ashamed of their detestable acts?
Not at all; they felt no shame,
and did not even know how to blush.
So they will fall along with the fallen;
when I punish them they will stumble,’ says Yahweh.
13 ‘I will surely gather them in,’[c] declares Yahweh;
‘there are no grapes on the vine,
nor figs on the fig tree;
even the leaf has withered,
and what I gave them passes away from them.’”[d]
14 Why are we sitting here?
Assemble! Let us enter the walled towns
and meet our end there;
for Yahweh our God has sentenced us to die
and made us drink water laced with poison,[e]
since against Yahweh we have sinned.
15 We looked for peace, but no good came;
for a time of healing, but see, terror.
16 The snorting of his horses is heard from Dan;
at the noise of his chargers’ neighing
all the land trembles.
They arrive and eat up the land and everything in it,
the town and its people.
17 “For look, I am letting loose snakes among you,
vipers against which no charm avails,
and they will bite you,” declares Yahweh.
18 Past all cure is my sorrow;[f]
faint within me is my heart.
19 Listen to my people crying
from a distant land:
“Is Yahweh no longer in Zion?
Is her King no longer there?”

"Why did they make me angry with their carved idols
and their worthless foreign gods?"
20 "The harvest is past, the summer is ended,
and we are not saved."
21 For the wound of the daughter of my people I am wounded;
I mourn; dismay has taken hold of me.
22 Is there no balm[g] in Gilead?
Is there no physician there?
Why then has the healing of the daughter of my people
not gone up?[h]

Notes

- a (8:7) The identification of these birds is uncertain; Hebrew sus or sis may be the swift or the swallow.
- b (8:11) The Septuagint lacks verses 11–12 (Brenton), which repeat 6:14–15.
- c (8:13) Or "I will make an end of them"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- d (8:13) The Hebrew of this line is obscure; the Septuagint lacks it (Brenton).
- e (8:14) Hebrew "water of rosh," a poisonous plant, perhaps hemlock or poppy.
- f (8:18) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- g (8:22) Hebrew tsori, an aromatic resin used as medicine, for which Gilead, east of the Jordan, was famous (Genesis 37:25). The plant is uncertain; suggestions include mastic and the balsam tree.
- h (8:22) That is, the new flesh has not grown over the wound. In Hebrew, 9:1 is numbered 8:23.

Chapter 9

1 Oh that my head were waters,
and my eyes a fountain of tears,
that I might weep day and night
for the slain of the daughter of my people![a]
2 Oh that I had in the wilderness
a lodging place for wayfarers,
that I might leave my people
and go away from them!
For they are all adulterers,
a company of traitors.
3 They bend their tongue like their bow;
falsehood and not faithfulness has grown strong in the land;

for they proceed from evil to evil,
and me they do not know, declares Yahweh.
4 Guard yourselves, each against his friend,
and rely on no brother;
for each brother is a heel-grabber,[b]
and each friend peddles slander.
5 Everyone cheats his neighbor,
and nobody tells the truth;
they have trained their tongues to lie;
they wear themselves out doing wrong.
6 Your dwelling is in the midst of deceit;
through deceit they refuse to know me, declares Yahweh.
7 Therefore thus says Yahweh of Armies:
"See, I will refine them and test them,
for what else can I do, because of the daughter of my people?
8 A death-dealing arrow is their tongue;
treachery is its speech;
with his lips a man greets his friend with "Peace,"
but inwardly he plots to waylay him.
9 Shall I not punish them for these things?" declares Yahweh,
"and on a nation such as this
shall my soul not take vengeance?"
10 Over the hills I will lift up weeping and lament,
and over the wilderness grazing lands a dirge,
for they are scorched, with none passing through,
and no sound of cattle is heard;
the birds of the sky as well as the beasts
have fled away and gone.
11 "Jerusalem I will turn into rubble heaps,
a haunt of jackals,
and Judah's towns into a waste
where no one lives."
12 What man is wise enough to grasp this? To whom has Yahweh's mouth spoken, so that he can explain it? For what cause has the land perished, scorched like the desert, with none passing through?

13 And Yahweh said, “Because they have forsaken my law that I set
before them, and have not obeyed my voice or walked in it, 14 but have
walked after the stubbornness of their own hearts and after the Baals,
as their fathers taught them. 15 Therefore thus says Yahweh of Armies,
the God of Israel: See, I will feed this people with wormwood, and
give them poisoned water to drink. 16 I will scatter them among the
nations whom neither they nor their fathers have known, and I will
send the sword after them, until I have consumed them.”
17 This is what Yahweh of Armies says:
“Think about it, and summon the women who mourn;
send for the women who are skilled at it;
18 let them hurry and lift a dirge over us,
till our eyes stream with tears
and our lashes drip with water.
19 For a sound of wailing is heard from Zion:
‘How we are ruined!
We are utterly ashamed,
because we have left the land,
because they have cast down our dwellings.’”
20 Hear, O women, the word of Yahweh,
and let your ear receive the word of his mouth;
teach your daughters a lament,
and each her neighbor a dirge.
21 For death has climbed in through our windows;
it has come into our strongholds,
cutting down the little ones in the street
and the youths in the public squares.
22 Say this: “So declares Yahweh:
‘Human corpses will lie
like manure across the open field,
like swaths of grain behind the harvester,
with no one to gather them up.’”
23 This is what Yahweh says:
“The sage must not glory in his wisdom,

nor the strong man glory in his strength,
nor the wealthy man glory in his wealth;
24 rather, if anyone would glory, let him glory in this:
that he has insight and knows me,
that I am Yahweh, who acts with steadfast love,
with justice and with righteousness on the earth.
For in these I take pleasure," declares Yahweh.
25 "See, days are coming," declares Yahweh, "when I will punish all
those who are circumcised merely in the flesh: 26 Egypt, Judah, Edom,
the sons of Ammon, Moab, and all who clip the corners of their hair,[c]
who dwell in the wilderness; for all these nations are uncircumcised,
and all the house of Israel is uncircumcised in heart."

Notes

- a (9:1) In Hebrew, verse 1 is numbered 8:23, and verses 2–26 are numbered 9:1–25.
- b (9:4) Hebrew ʿaqov yaʿqov, "supplanting he supplants," a play on the name Jacob (Genesis 27:36).
- c (9:26) Or "who dwell in the desert with clipped temples," a custom of certain Arab tribes; compare Leviticus 19:27.

Chapter 10

1 Hear the word that Yahweh speaks to you, O house of Israel.
2 This is what Yahweh says:
"Do not copy the ways of the nations
or be terrified by signs in the sky,
though the nations are terrified by them;
3 for the practices of the peoples are mere vapor.
Someone fells a tree in the woods,
and a carver shapes it with his chisel.
4 They adorn it with silver and with gold;
they fasten it with nails and hammers
so that it cannot move.
5 They are like a scarecrow in a melon patch,[a]
mute and unable to talk;
they must be hauled about,
having no power to walk.
Have no fear of them,

for harm is beyond them,
and good is beyond them too."
6 There is none like you, O Yahweh;[b]
you are great, and your name is great in might.
7 Who could fail to fear you, King of the nations?
For to you it rightly belongs;
for among all the sages of the nations
and throughout their realms
none can compare with you.
8 They are altogether stupid and foolish;
the instruction of idols is but wood.
9 Hammered silver is imported from Tarshish,
and gold from Uphaz;[c]
it is the work of a craftsman and a goldsmith's hands;
they are dressed in blue and purple;
they are all made by skilled workers.
10 But Yahweh is God in truth;
he is the living God, the King for all ages.
When he is angry the earth shakes,
and the nations cannot withstand his fury.
11 This is what you are to tell them:[d] "The gods that never made heaven and earth will vanish from the earth and from beneath these skies."
12 He made the earth by his power;
he established the world by his wisdom,
and by his understanding stretched out the heavens.
13 At the sound of his voice the waters in the skies roar,
and he lifts the clouds from the far edges of the earth.
He fashions lightning to go with the rain,
and draws the wind out of his treasuries.
14 Every man is stupid, without knowledge;
every goldsmith is put to shame by his idol,
for his molten images are falsehood,
and there is no breath in them.
15 They are vapor, a work of mockery;
in the time of their punishment they shall perish.

16 The Portion of Jacob[e] is nothing like these,
for he formed everything,
and Israel is the tribe he claimed as his own;
Yahweh of Armies is his name.
17 Pick up your pack from the ground,
you who live under siege!
18 For this is what Yahweh says:
"Look, I am about to hurl away the people of the land
this time,
and I will bring trouble on them
so that they will find out."[f]
19 How I suffer from my injury!
My wound is severe.
Yet I said, "This is my sickness,
and I must put up with it."
20 My tent has been wrecked,
and all its ropes have snapped;
my children have left me
and are gone;
no one is left to pitch my tent
or hang up my curtains.
21 For the shepherds are stupid
and do not inquire of Yahweh;
therefore they have not prospered,
and all their flock is scattered.
22 Listen, a rumor! See, it comes—
a great commotion out of the north country,
to make the cities of Judah a desolation,
a lair of jackals.
23 I know, O Yahweh, that the way of man is not in himself;
it is not in man who walks to direct his steps.
24 Discipline me, Yahweh, but fairly;
not in anger, or you will reduce me to nothing.
25 Empty your fury on the nations that do not acknowledge you,
and on the clans that never invoke your name,

for they have eaten up Jacob;
they have eaten him and finished him off,
and made his pasture a waste.

Notes

- a (10:5) The Septuagint arranges verses 5 and 9 differently, placing the substance of verse 9 within verse 5.
- b (10:6) The Septuagint lacks verses 6–8 and 10 (Brenton). A Hebrew manuscript from Qumran (4QJer-b) is reported to share this shorter form of the chapter.
- c (10:9) Uphaz, an unknown place; some ancient witnesses read Ophir.
- d (10:11) Verse 11 is in Aramaic, the only Aramaic verse in Jeremiah, and it contains a wordplay: the gods who did not "make" (ʻavadu) the heavens shall "perish" (yevadu).
- e (10:16) That is, Yahweh, the one who belongs to Jacob as his share.
- f (10:18) Or "that they may be found"; the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 11

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 2 "Hear
the terms of this covenant, and speak them to Judah's men and to
Jerusalem's residents. 3 Tell them, 'This is what Yahweh, Israel's God,
says: Cursed is the man who does not heed the terms of this covenant,
4 which I laid upon your fathers on the day I brought them out of
Egypt, out of the iron-smelting furnace, saying: Listen to my voice
and carry out all that I command you. So you will be my people, and
I will be your God, 5 that I may keep the oath I swore to your fathers,
to give them a land flowing with milk and honey, as it is at this day.'"
Then I answered, "Amen,[a] Yahweh."
6 And Yahweh told me, "Proclaim all these words in Judah's towns
and Jerusalem's streets: 'Hear the terms of this covenant and carry
them out. 7 For I solemnly warned your fathers from the day I brought
them up out of Egypt down to this day, warning them early and late,
saying, Listen to my voice.[b] 8 Yet they would not listen or turn their
ear, but each walked in the obstinacy of his evil heart. So I brought
upon them all the terms of this covenant, which I had charged them
to keep, and which they did not keep.'"
9 Then Yahweh said to me, "A conspiracy has been uncovered among
Judah's men and Jerusalem's residents. 10 They have gone back to
the guilt of their forefathers, who would not hear my words; they

too have gone after other gods to serve them. Israel's house and Judah's house have broken my covenant that I cut with their fathers.
11 Therefore this is what Yahweh says: Look, I am bringing on them a calamity they cannot escape; they will cry to me, but I will not listen.
12 Then Judah's towns and Jerusalem's residents will go and cry to the gods to whom they burn offerings, but those gods will give them no rescue whatever in the hour of their calamity. 13 Indeed, O Judah, your gods number as many as your towns, and the altars you have erected to the Shame[c] number as many as Jerusalem's streets—altars for sending up smoke to Baal.
14 "And you—intercede not for this people; raise no plea or entreaty for them, for I will refuse to listen at the time they call on me in their calamity.
15 What right has my beloved in my house,
when she has worked out her many schemes?
Can vows[d] and holy flesh
take your calamity from you?
Then you could exult.
16 Yahweh once called you a green olive tree,
beautiful and full of fine fruit.
But with a loud storm roar
he has set it on fire,
and its branches are broken.[e]
17 Yahweh of Armies, who planted you, has pronounced calamity against you, because of the evil that Israel's house and Judah's house have done, provoking me by burning offerings to Baal."
18 Yahweh disclosed it to me, and so I learned of it;
then you let me see what they were doing.
19 But I was like a docile lamb
led away to the butcher;
I did not know it was against me
they had hatched their plots:
"Let us destroy the tree with its sap;[f]
let us cut him off from the land of the living,
that his name may be remembered no more."

20 But you, Yahweh of Armies, who judge rightly,
who test the inmost parts[g] and the heart,
let me see your vengeance upon them,
for to you I have laid bare my cause.
21 Therefore this is what Yahweh says about the people of Anathoth
who are trying to kill you and tell you, "Do not prophesy in Yahweh's
name, or we will kill you"— 22 therefore this is what Yahweh of Armies
says: "See, I will call them to account. Their young men will die by the
sword; their sons and daughters will die by famine. 23 None of them
will survive, for I will bring disaster on the people of Anathoth in the
year when I punish them."

Notes

- a (11:5) Hebrew ʾamen, "surely, so be it," the response to the covenant curses (Deuteronomy 27:15–26).
- b (11:7) The Septuagint lacks verse 7 and most of verse 8, reading only "But they did them not" (Brenton).
- c (11:13) Hebrew bosheth, a contemptuous substitute for Baal.
- d (11:15) Following the Septuagint, which has "prayers and holy offerings" (Brenton); the Hebrew reads "the many," which is difficult.
- e (11:16) The Hebrew of verses 15–16 is uncertain in places.
- f (11:19) Hebrew "with its bread"; the translation follows a slight change of the text, or else read "its fruit."
- g (11:20) Hebrew "kidneys," regarded as the seat of the emotions.

Chapter 12

1 Righteous are you, Yahweh,
when I bring a case before you;
yet I would argue my cause with you:
Why does the path of the wicked prosper?
Why do all the treacherous live at ease?
2 You plant them, and they take root;
they grow and bear fruit.
Near are you in their mouth,
but far from their inmost parts.
3 But you, Yahweh, know me;
you see me and test my heart toward you.

Drag them off like sheep for slaughter,
and set them apart for the day of killing.
4 Till when shall the earth lie mourning,
the herbage of the countryside dried up?
For the wickedness of its dwellers
beast and bird have perished,
for they said, "He will not see what becomes of us."
5 "If runners on foot have tired you out,
how can you race against horses?
And if only in a quiet land you feel secure,[a]
what will you do in the Jordan's jungle?[b]
6 For even your brothers and your father's house,
even they have dealt treacherously with you;
even they shout loudly after you.
Do not trust them,
though they speak fair words to you.
7 "I have abandoned my house;
I have cast off my heritage;
I have handed the darling of my soul
into the grip of her enemies.
8 My heritage has turned on me
like a lion in the forest;
she has raised her voice against me;
therefore I hate her.
9 Is my heritage to me a speckled bird of prey?[c]
Are the birds of prey against her on every side?
Go, assemble all the beasts of the field;
bring them to devour.
10 Many shepherds have ruined my vineyard;
they have trampled my portion;
they have turned my pleasant portion
into a desolate wilderness.
11 It has been turned into a wasteland;
waste and mourning, it lies before me.

All the land is made a waste,
since no one takes it to heart.
12 Across the barren hills in the wilderness
raiders have arrived,
for Yahweh's sword is devouring
from one end of the land to the other;
no one is safe.
13 Wheat they sowed, but thorns they reaped;
they have worn themselves out to no profit.
Be ashamed[d] of your harvests
because of the fierce anger of Yahweh."
14 This is what Yahweh says concerning all my evil neighbors who touch the heritage I gave my people Israel to possess: "See, I am uprooting them from their land, and the house of Judah I will uproot from among them. 15 But after I have pulled them out, I will have compassion on them again and bring each of them back to his own inheritance and his own land. 16 And if they will diligently learn the ways of my people, to swear by my name, 'As Yahweh lives,' even as they taught my people to swear by Baal, then they shall be built up in the midst of my people. 17 But if any nation will not listen, then I will pluck up that nation, plucking it up and destroying it," declares Yahweh.

Notes

- a (12:5) Or "if only in a peaceful land you feel secure."
- b (12:5) Hebrew "the pride of the Jordan," the dense growth along the river, home of lions (49:19).
- c (12:9) The Hebrew is uncertain; the Septuagint reads, "Is not my inheritance to me a hyena's cave?" (Brenton, modernized).
- d (12:13) Or, with a change of vowels, "They shall be ashamed."

Chapter 13

1 This is what Yahweh said to me: "Go and buy yourself a linen waistcloth[a] and wrap it about your loins, but do not let it get into water." 2 So I bought a waistcloth as Yahweh directed and wrapped it about my loins. 3 Then Yahweh's word came to me a second time: 4 "Take the waistcloth you bought, the one about your loins, and set

out for Perath;[b] hide it there in a cleft of the rock." 5 So I went and hid
it at Perath, as Yahweh had ordered me. 6 After many days Yahweh
said to me, "Set out for Perath, and retrieve from there the waistcloth
I ordered you to hide there." 7 So I went to Perath, dug, and took
the waistcloth from the place where I had hidden it. And look—the
waistcloth was rotted, fit for nothing at all.
8 Then Yahweh's word came to me: 9 "This is what Yahweh says: Just
so will I rot the pride of Judah and the great pride of Jerusalem. 10
This evil people, who refuse to hear my words, who walk in their
own obstinate hearts and go after other gods to serve them and bow
to them, shall be like this waistcloth, fit for nothing at all. 11 For just
as a waistcloth hugs a man's waist, so I bound to myself all Israel's
house and all Judah's house," declares Yahweh, "to be my people, my
renown, my praise, and my honor; yet they refused to listen.
12 "Speak to them also this word: 'This is what Yahweh, Israel's God,
says: Every jar is to be filled with wine.' And when they answer
you, 'Do we not know perfectly well that every jar is to be filled
with wine?' 13 then say to them, 'This is what Yahweh says: I am
about to make everyone living in this land drunk—the kings who
sit on David's throne, the priests, the prophets and all the people of
Jerusalem. 14 And I will smash them one against another, fathers and
sons alike,' declares Yahweh. 'I will show no pity, nor spare, nor have
compassion, so as not to destroy them.'"
15 Listen and give ear; be not proud,
for Yahweh has spoken.
16 Honor Yahweh your God
before he brings darkness,
before your feet trip
on the dusky mountains,
and while you hope for light
17 But if you will not hear,
my soul will weep in secret for your pride;
my eye will weep bitterly and run down with tears,
because Yahweh's flock has been taken captive.

18 Say to the king and to the queen mother:[c]
"Sit down low,
for your splendid crown
has come down from your heads."
19 The towns of the Negev[d] are shut up,
with none to open them;
all Judah is carried into exile,
wholly carried into exile.
20 Lift up your eyes and see
those coming from the north.
Where is the flock that was given you,
your beautiful flock?
21 What will you say when he puts over you as ruler
the very people you trained
to be your close allies?[e]
Will pain not grip you
like a woman in labor?
22 And if you wonder,
"Why did this happen to me?"—
it is the size of your guilt
that has stripped off your skirts
and left you violated.[f]
23 Can a Cushite[g] alter his skin
or a leopard remove its spots?
Then you could also do good,
you who have learned only evil.
24 I will scatter them like chaff
driven by the wind of the desert.
25 This is your lot,
the portion I have measured out to you, declares Yahweh,
because you have forgotten me
and trusted in falsehood.
26 I myself will pull your skirts up over your face,
so that your shame is exposed.

27 Your adultery and your lustful cries,
your shameless prostitution
on the hills and in the fields—
I have seen your detestable acts.
Woe to you, Jerusalem!
How long will you stay unclean?

Notes

- a (13:1) Hebrew ʾezor, a garment worn next to the body, perhaps a loincloth or sash.
- b (13:4) Hebrew Perath is the usual name of the Euphrates, about 350 miles (560 kilometers) away, and the Septuagint reads "the Euphrates" (Brenton). Some interpreters think of Parah (Joshua 18:23), a village about 4 miles (6 kilometers) from Anathoth.
- c (13:18) Hebrew gevirah, "great lady," the king's mother, who held an official position; probably Nehushta, mother of Jehoiachin (2 Kings 24:8).
- d (13:19) Negev, "dry land," the arid south of Judah.
- e (13:21) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- f (13:22) A euphemism for sexual violation.
- g (13:23) Cushite, a man from Cush (the upper Nile region, modern Sudan), known for dark skin.

Chapter 14

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Jeremiah concerning the drought:[a]
2 "Judah mourns,
and her gates languish;
her people lie in black upon the ground,
and the cry of Jerusalem goes up.
3 Their great men dispatch their lads for water;
to the pits they go;
no water do they find;
back they come, their jars empty;
shamed and humiliated,
they muffle their heads.
4 Since the soil is shattered,
since no rain has fallen on the land,
the farmers are dismayed;
they muffle their heads.

5 Even the doe in the field
gives birth and forsakes her fawn,
because there is no grass.
6 The wild donkeys stand on the bare heights;
they pant for air like jackals;
their eyes fail
because there is no herbage.
7 “Although our wrongs accuse us,
Yahweh, take action for the sake of your name;
our acts of unfaithfulness are many;
we have sinned against you.
8 O Hope of Israel,
its Savior in time of trouble,
why should you be like a sojourner in the land,
like a traveler who turns aside to lodge for a night?
9 Why are you like someone bewildered,
like a warrior unable to rescue?
But you are here among us, Yahweh,
and we bear your name;
do not abandon us.”
10 This is what Yahweh says of this people:
“So well have they loved to wander;
their feet they have not restrained;
therefore Yahweh does not accept them;
now he will remember their iniquity
and punish their sins.”
11 Yahweh said to me, “Do not pray for this people’s welfare. 12 When they fast, I will not listen to their cry; when they present burnt offerings and grain offerings, I will not accept them; instead I will finish them off with sword, famine and plague.”
13 Then I said, “Ah, Lord Yahweh! Look, the prophets keep telling them, ‘You shall not see the sword, nor shall famine come upon you; I will give you lasting peace in this place.’” 14 Yahweh told me, “These prophets are prophesying lies in my name. I did not send them or order them or speak to them. They are prophesying to you a false

vision, worthless fortune-telling and the deceit of their own minds.[b]
15 So this is what Yahweh says about the prophets who prophesy in
my name though I never sent them, and who keep saying, 'No sword
or famine will touch this land': By sword and by famine those very
prophets will be finished off. 16 The people they prophesy to will lie
in Jerusalem's streets, thrown out and dying from famine and the
sword, and no one will bury them—not they, nor their wives, sons or
daughters. I will pour their own wickedness back on them.
17 "Tell them this message:
'May my eyes overflow with tears
night and day without stopping,
for my people's virgin daughter has suffered a crushing blow,
a terribly severe wound.
18 If I go out into the field,
look—those slain by the sword!
And if I enter the city,
look—the diseases of famine!
For both prophet and priest roam about in a land they know not.'"[c]
19 Have you cast Judah off completely?
Is Zion abhorrent to your soul?
Why have you smitten us
past all mending?
We hoped for peace, and nothing good arrived;
for a season of healing, and see—panic.
20 We acknowledge, O Yahweh, our wickedness,
the iniquity of our fathers,
for we have sinned against you.
21 For your name's sake, do not despise us;
bring no disgrace on the throne of your glory;
keep in mind your covenant with us, and annul it not.
22 Is there anyone among the worthless gods of the nations who can
send rain?
Or do the skies pour showers on their own?
Isn't it you, Yahweh our God?

We wait for you,
because you alone make all these things happen.

Notes

- a (14:1) Hebrew batstsaroth, “the times of dearth” or “the droughts.”
- b (14:14) Hebrew “heart.”
- c (14:18) Or “go off trading in a land they do not know”; the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 15

1 Then Yahweh said to me, “Even if Moses and Samuel stood before
me, my soul would not turn toward this people. Send them from my
presence; let them be gone!
2 If they ask you, ‘Where should we go?’ say to them, ‘This is what
Yahweh says:
“Death for those marked for death;
the sword for those marked for the sword;
famine for those marked for famine;
exile for those marked for exile.”’
3 I will appoint over them four kinds of destroyers,” declares Yahweh:
“the sword to slay, the dogs to drag away, and the birds of the sky
and the beasts of the earth to devour and to destroy.
4 I will turn them into an object of dread for every realm on earth, on
account of what Manasseh[a] son of Hezekiah, Judah’s king, committed
in Jerusalem.
5 “For who will take pity on you, Jerusalem?
Who will lament over you?
Who will step aside
to inquire how you fare?
6 You have cast me off, declares Yahweh;
backward you keep going;
so I have stretched out my hand against you and destroyed you;
I am weary of relenting.
7 I have scattered them with a pitchfork
at the gates of the land;
I have made them childless and destroyed my people;
they have not given up their ways.

8 I have made their widows outnumber
the grains of sand by the sea;
upon the mother of the young warriors
I have brought a ravager at midday;
I have let alarm and dismay
drop on her without warning.
9 The mother of seven grows faint;
she gasps out her life;
her sun has set while daylight remained;
humiliated is she, and abashed.
Whoever of them survive I will hand to the sword
in their foes' presence, declares Yahweh."
10 How miserable I am, mother, that you gave birth to me,
a man who brings quarrels and conflict to the whole country!
I have neither loaned money nor borrowed it,
yet everyone curses me.
11 Yahweh said, "Surely I will set you free for good;[b]
surely I will make the enemy plead with you
in the time of evil and in the time of distress.
12 Can one break iron,
iron from the north, and bronze?[c]
13 Your riches and your stores I will hand over as spoil, at no cost,
for all your sins, in every part of your land.
14 I will make you slaves to your foes[d]
in a country unknown to you,
for my anger has lit a fire
that will blaze against you."
15 Yahweh, you understand;
keep me in mind and come to my aid;
take revenge for me on those who hound me.
Do not, through your patience with them, snatch me away;
consider how for you I endure insult.
16 When your words came, I devoured them;
they became my joy
and my heart's delight,

because I bear your name,
Yahweh, God of Armies.
17 Never did I sit among the revelers
or make merry with them;
under your hand I sat by myself,
for you had filled me with fury.
18 Why has my agony no end,
my wound no cure, past all healing?
Will you indeed prove to me a treacherous wadi,
a stream whose waters cannot be relied on?
19 So Yahweh answered:
"If you come back, I will restore you
and you will serve me.
If you speak what is valuable and not what is worthless,
you will be my spokesman.
They may turn to you,
but you must not turn to them.
20 I will turn you into a fortified wall of bronze
for this people;
they will fight you,
but they will not defeat you,
for I am with you
to save and rescue you, declares Yahweh.
21 I will rescue you out of the power of evildoers,
and ransom you from the clutch of tyrants."

Notes

- a (15:4) Manasseh reigned about 697–642 B.C.; his sins are recounted in 2 Kings 21:1–18 and 23:26–27.
- b (15:11) The Hebrew of verses 11–12 is difficult; the Septuagint differs considerably, reading, "So be it, Lord, in their prosperity" (Brenton). Some ancient witnesses read the verse as Jeremiah's words.
- c (15:12) Or "Can iron and bronze break iron from the north?"
- d (15:14) So many Hebrew manuscripts, the Septuagint, and Syriac (compare 17:4); the standard Hebrew text reads "I will make them pass over with your enemies."

Chapter 16

1 Yahweh's word came to me once more: 2 "Take no wife for yourself,
and father no sons or daughters in this place. 3 For here is Yahweh's
word concerning the boys and girls born in this place, and concerning
the women who give them birth and the men who father them in this
land: 4 They will perish of deadly diseases. None will mourn them,
none will bury them; they will lie like manure on the face of the soil.
By sword and by famine they will be finished off, and their carcasses
will feed the birds of the sky and the beasts of the earth.
5 "For so says Yahweh: Enter no house of the mourning banquet;[a] go
not in to lament or to show sympathy, for from this people I have
taken away my peace," declares Yahweh, "my steadfast love and my
tender mercies.[b] 6 Great and small alike will perish in this land. They
will go unburied; no one will mourn for them, nor gash himself,
nor shave his head on their account. 7 No one will break bread for
the mourner to console him for the dead, nor will anyone hand him
the cup of consolation for his father or his mother. 8 Into a house of
feasting likewise you must not go, to sit down with them to eat and
drink. 9 For this is what Yahweh of Armies, Israel's God, says: Look,
before your eyes and in your days I am silencing in this place the
sound of merriment and the sound of joy, the voice of bridegroom
and the voice of bride.
10 "And when you report all these words to this people and they ask
you, 'On what grounds has Yahweh decreed all this great calamity
against us? What is our guilt? What sin have we committed against
Yahweh our God?' 11 then answer them, 'It is because your fathers
abandoned me,' declares Yahweh, 'and went after other gods, serving
them and bowing down to them. Me they abandoned, and my law
they did not keep. 12 And you have done worse than your fathers, for
look, each of you walks in the obstinacy of his evil heart, refusing
to listen to me. 13 So I will hurl you out of this land into a land that
neither you nor your fathers have known, and there you will serve
other gods day and night, for I will show you no favor.'
14 "However, look, the time is coming," declares Yahweh, "when people
will no longer say, 'As surely as Yahweh lives, who brought the

Israelites out of Egypt,' 15 but instead, 'By the life of Yahweh, who led
Israel's sons up out of the north country and out of every land to
which he had scattered them.' For back to their own soil I will restore
them, the soil I bestowed on their ancestors.
16 "Look, I am sending for many fishermen," declares Yahweh, "and
they will fish them out. Afterward I will send for many hunters, and
they will hunt them down on every mountain and every hill and out
of the clefts of the rocks. 17 For my eyes are on all their ways; they are
not concealed from my face, nor is their guilt hidden from my eyes.
18 First[c] I will repay double for their guilt and their sin, because they
have polluted my land with the carcasses of their detestable idols and
filled my heritage with their abominations."
19 Yahweh, my might and my fortress,
my shelter when trouble comes,
from earth's farthest reaches
the nations will come to you, saying:
"Our fathers owned nothing but a lie,
a puff of air, useless through and through.
20 Can a man make gods for himself?
Such are no gods!"
21 "So look, I will teach them—
this one time I will teach them
my power and my strength,
and they will know that my name is Yahweh."

Notes

- a (16:5) Hebrew marzeaḥ, a ritual banquet, here held for mourning.
- b (16:5) The Septuagint lacks "my steadfast love and my compassion" and the first half of verse 6 (Brenton).
- c (16:18) The Septuagint lacks "First" (Brenton).

Chapter 17

1 "The sin of Judah is written with an iron pen,
engraved with a diamond tip[a]
on the tablet of their hearts
and on the corners of their altars,[b]

2 while their sons remember their altars
and their Asherah poles[c]
beside every leafy tree
on the high hills,
3 O my mountain set in the countryside!
Your riches and every treasure of yours I will hand over as spoil,
your shrines too, for the sin in every part of your land.
4 Through your own fault you will lose hold
of the inheritance I bestowed on you,
and I will make you slaves to your foes
in a country strange to you,
for you have lit a fire in my nostrils
that will blaze for all time."
5 This is what Yahweh says:
"Cursed is the man who relies on mortal man
and makes flesh the arm he leans on,
while his heart veers away from Yahweh.
6 He will be like a juniper[d] in the Arabah;
he will not see when good arrives,
but will settle in the scorched places of the wilderness,
a salt land where no one lives.
7 "Blessed is the man who relies on Yahweh,
whose confidence Yahweh is.
8 He will be like a tree set by the water,
that pushes out its roots toward the stream;
it has no fear when the heat arrives,
and its foliage stays lush;
in a year of drought it is not anxious,
and it never stops yielding fruit."
9 More tortuous[e] than all else is the heart,
and desperately sick;
who can fathom it?
10 "I, Yahweh, probe the heart
and examine the inmost parts,

to repay each man according to his ways,
according to the fruit of his deeds."
11 Like a partridge that hatches eggs it did not lay
is the man who gets riches unjustly;
in the middle of his days they will abandon him,
and at his end he will prove a fool.
12 A throne of glory, set on high from the beginning,
is the place of our sanctuary.
13 O Yahweh, Hope of Israel,
all who abandon you shall be put to shame;
those who turn from you[f] shall be written in the dust,
for they have abandoned Yahweh,
the spring of living water.
14 Heal me, O Yahweh, and I shall be healed;
save me, and I shall be saved,
for you are my praise.
15 Look, they keep saying to me,
"Where is Yahweh's word?
Let it come, then!"
16 But I have not pressed you to send calamity,[g]
nor have I longed for the day of disaster;
you know it.
What came from my lips
was open before your face.
17 Do not become a terror to me;
you are my refuge in the day of calamity.
18 Let my persecutors be put to shame, but not me;
let them be dismayed, but not me;
bring on them the day of calamity;
with double destruction destroy them!
19 This is what Yahweh said to me: "Go and stand in the People's Gate,[h]
by which Judah's kings come in and go out, and in all the gates of
Jerusalem, 20 and say to them, 'Hear the word of Yahweh, you kings
of Judah, and all Judah, and all Jerusalem's residents who come in by
these gates. 21 This is what Yahweh says: Guard yourselves, as you

value your lives, and carry no load on the Sabbath day, nor bring it in through Jerusalem's gates. 22 Carry no load out of your houses on the Sabbath day, and do no work at all, but keep the Sabbath day holy, as I commanded your fathers. 23 Yet they would not listen or turn their ear, but stiffened their necks so as not to hear or take correction. 24 But if you diligently heed me, declares Yahweh, and carry no burden in by this city's gates on the Sabbath, but treat the Sabbath as holy by doing no labor on it, 25 then through the gates of this city will enter kings and princes who sit on David's throne, riding in chariots and on horses, they and their princes, Judah's men and Jerusalem's residents; and this city will be inhabited forever. 26 And people will come from the towns of Judah and the places around Jerusalem, from the land of Benjamin, from the Shephelah,[i] from the hill country, and from the Negev, bringing burnt offerings and sacrifices, grain offerings and frankincense, and bringing thank offerings to Yahweh's house. 27 But if you will not listen to me, to keep the Sabbath day holy and not to carry a load as you enter Jerusalem's gates on the Sabbath day, then I will kindle a fire in its gates, and it will consume the palaces of Jerusalem and will not be quenched.'"

Notes

- a (17:1) Hebrew shamir, a very hard stone, perhaps emery or diamond.
- b (17:1) The Septuagint lacks verses 1–4 (Brenton). Verses 3–4 partly repeat 15:13–14.
- c (17:2) Asherah, a Canaanite goddess; her symbol was a wooden pole or stylized tree.
- d (17:6) Hebrew ʿarʿar, a desert shrub, perhaps the juniper or a dwarf tamarisk; the Septuagint has "wild tamarisk" (Brenton).
- e (17:9) Hebrew ʿaqov, "crooked, deceitful," recalling the name Jacob. The Septuagint reads, "The heart is deep beyond all things, and it is the man" (Brenton), reflecting Hebrew ʿamoq, "deep," and ʾenosh, "man," for ʾanush, "sick."
- f (17:13) Hebrew "from me."
- g (17:16) Or, with a slight change, "I have not run away from being a shepherd after you"; the Hebrew is uncertain.
- h (17:19) Or "the Gate of the Sons of the People"; its location is unknown.
- i (17:26) Shephelah, "lowland," the foothills between Judah's hill country and the coastal plain.

Chapter 18

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 2 “Get up and go
down to the potter’s workshop, and there I will tell you what I have
to say.” 3 So I went down to the potter’s workshop, and look—he was
at work on the double wheel.[a] 4 Whenever the vessel he was shaping
from the clay was spoiled in the potter’s hand, he would rework it
into another vessel, as seemed right to the potter to make.
5 Then Yahweh’s word came to me: 6 “House of Israel, can I not deal
with you as this potter does?” declares Yahweh. “Look, as clay in the
potter’s hand, so are you in my hand, O house of Israel. 7 At one
moment I may speak of a nation or a kingdom, to uproot and pull
down and destroy it; 8 but if that nation I spoke of turns from its evil,
I relent of the calamity I planned to bring on it. 9 At another moment
I may speak of a nation or a kingdom, to build and to plant it; 10 yet
should it do what is evil before me, refusing to heed my voice, I will
think better of the good I had said I would do for it. 11 Now speak
to the people of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem: ‘This is what
Yahweh says: Look, I am preparing disaster for you and making plans
against you. Each of you must turn from your evil way and change
your ways and actions.’ 12 But they will answer, ‘No use! Our own
schemes we will pursue; each of us will do as his stubborn, evil heart
dictates.’
13 “Therefore this is what Yahweh says:
Ask among the nations:
who ever heard the like of this?
A thing most horrible
has the virgin Israel done.
14 Does the snow of Lebanon leave
the crags of the field?[b]
Are the cold flowing waters
from afar ever dried up?[c]
15 Yet my people have forgotten me;
to vapor they burn offerings;
they made them stumble in their ways,
the ancient roads,

to walk in bypaths,
not a highway built up,
16 to turn their country into an appalling waste,
an object of perpetual whistling;
all who travel past it shudder
and wag their heads.
17 Like the east wind I will scatter them
before the enemy;
my back, not my face,[d] I will show them
in the day of their calamity."
18 Then they said, "Come on, let us make plans against Jeremiah, because teaching will not disappear from the priests, advice from the wise or messages from the prophets. Come on, let us attack him with words, and pay no attention to anything he says."
19 Give heed to me, O Yahweh,
and listen to the voice of my adversaries.
20 Should evil be the payment for good?
Yet they have dug a pit to trap me.
Remember that I stood in front of you
and spoke well of them,
to turn your anger away from them.
21 Therefore hand their sons over to famine;
pour them out to the power of the sword;
let their wives become childless and widowed;
let their men be slain by death,
their young men struck by the sword in battle.
22 Let a cry be heard from their houses,
when you bring raiders on them suddenly,
for they have dug a pit to seize me
and hidden snares for my feet.
23 Yet you, Yahweh, know
all their plotting against me to kill me.
Do not cover over their iniquity,
nor blot out their sin from before you.

Let them be overthrown before you;
deal with them in the time of your anger.

Notes

- a (18:3) Hebrew "the two stones," the upper and lower wheels of the potter's wheel, turned by the feet.
- b (18:14) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain; perhaps "the rock of Sirion," another name for Hermon.
- c (18:14) Or "Are the foreign, cold, flowing waters ever plucked up?"; the Hebrew is difficult.
- d (18:17) So the Hebrew consonants, read with different vowels; some ancient witnesses read "I will look on their back, not their face."

Chapter 19

1 This is what Yahweh said: "Go and buy a potter's earthenware jar,[a]
and take with you some of the elders of the people and of the senior
priests, 2 and go out to the Valley of Ben-hinnom at the entry of the
Potsherd Gate,[b] and proclaim there the words I tell you. 3 Declare,
'Listen to Yahweh's word, O kings of Judah and you who live in
Jerusalem. So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: I am about to
bring on this place a disaster so great that whoever hears of it, both
his ears will ring. 4 For they have abandoned me and made this place
alien, burning offerings in it to other gods whom neither they nor
their fathers nor Judah's kings had known; and they have filled this
place with the blood of innocents, 5 and have built the high places of
Baal to burn their sons in the fire as burnt offerings to Baal—a thing
I never commanded or spoke of, nor did it enter my mind. 6 So, mark
it, the days are approaching, declares Yahweh, when no longer will
this place be named Topheth or Ben-hinnom's Valley, but Slaughter
Valley. 7 Here in this place I will drain away[c] the counsel of Judah and
Jerusalem; I will cause them to fall by the sword before their foes, by
the hand of those hunting for their lives, and I will hand over their
corpses to be eaten by the birds of the sky and the wild animals of the
earth. 8 I will make this city a horror and a thing to hiss at; everyone
who passes by it will be appalled and hiss because of all its wounds.
9 I will make them eat the flesh of their sons and daughters, and they

will eat one another's flesh during the siege and the hardship their enemies and those seeking their lives will inflict on them.'
10 "Then you shall break the jar before the eyes of the men who go
with you, 11 and tell them, 'This is what Yahweh of Armies says: In the
same way I will smash this people and this city, as someone smashes
a clay pot so that it cannot be repaired. They will bury the dead in
Topheth until there is no more room. 12 This is what I will do to this
place, declares Yahweh, and to its inhabitants, making this city like
Topheth. 13 The houses of Jerusalem and the houses of Judah's kings
shall be defiled like the place of Topheth—all the houses on whose
roofs they burned offerings to all the host of the heavens and poured
out drink offerings to other gods.'"
14 Then Jeremiah came from Topheth, where Yahweh had sent him to
prophesy, and he stood in the court of Yahweh's house and said to all
the people: 15 "So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: Mark this—
upon this city and all its villages I am bringing every disaster I have
decreed against it, because they made their necks rigid and would not
hear my words."

Notes

- a (19:1) Hebrew baqbuq, a narrow-necked flask; the name imitates the gurgling sound of pouring. Its sound anticipates the verb baqqothi, "I will empty out," in verse 7.
- b (19:2) Hebrew Harsith, perhaps the gate where broken pottery was discarded.
- c (19:7) Hebrew baqqothi, a play on baqbuq, "jar" (verse 1).

Chapter 20

1 Now Pashhur son of Immer, the priest, who was chief officer in
Yahweh's house, heard Jeremiah prophesying these things. 2 Then
Pashhur struck Jeremiah the prophet and put him in the stocks[a] at
the Upper Gate of Benjamin, in Yahweh's house. 3 On the following
day Pashhur let Jeremiah out of the stocks, and Jeremiah told him,
"Yahweh's name for you is not Pashhur, but Magor-missabib.[b] 4 For
this is what Yahweh says: Look, I will make you a terror to yourself
and to all your friends. They will fall by the sword of their enemies
while your eyes look on. And all Judah I will give into the hand of
the king of Babylon; he will carry them captive to Babylon and strike

them down with the sword. 5 All this city's riches, all its earnings, all
its valuables, and every treasure of Judah's kings I will hand over to
their foes, who will loot them, carry them off, and take them away
to Babylon. 6 As for you, Pashhur, you and all your household will
go away as captives. To Babylon you will come; there you will die
and there be buried, you and every friend of yours to whom you
prophesied lies."

7 You enticed me, O Yahweh, and I was enticed;[c]
you overpowered me, and you prevailed.
I have become a laughingstock all day;
everyone mocks me.
8 For whenever I speak, I cry out;
"Violence and ruin!" I shout.
For the word of Yahweh has become for me
a reproach and derision all day long.
9 Yet if I resolve, "I will not bring him to mind
or speak again in his name,"
it turns within my heart into a blazing fire
locked up in my bones;
I am worn out trying to contain it,
and I am not able.
10 For I hear many muttering,
"Terror all around!
Report him! Yes, let us report him!"
All who were at peace with me
wait for me to trip:
"Maybe he can be lured;
then we will get the better of him
and have our revenge."
11 But Yahweh stands by me like a fearsome champion;
so those who hound me will trip up;
they will not win.
Deeply disgraced they will be, because they fail;
an eternal dishonor, never to be forgotten.

12 O Yahweh of Armies, who test the righteous,
who see the inmost parts and the heart,
let me see your vengeance upon them,
for to you I have laid bare my cause.
13 Sing to Yahweh;
praise Yahweh!
For he has rescued the life of the needy
from the hand of evildoers.
14 A curse on the day
I came to birth!
The day my mother brought me forth—
may no blessing rest on it!
15 A curse on the man who carried word to my father,
"You have a son, a boy!"
and filled him with gladness.
16 Let that man be like the cities
that Yahweh overthrew without relenting;
let him hear a cry in the morning
and an alarm at noon,
17 because he did not slay me before birth,
that my mother might have been my tomb,
her womb pregnant for all time.
18 Why ever did I leave the womb
to look on trouble and grief,
and finish my days in disgrace?

Notes

- a (20:2) Hebrew mahpeketh, perhaps a device that held the body in a twisted posture.
- b (20:3) Magor-missabib, "terror on every side." The Septuagint reads "Exile" (Brenton) in place of the Hebrew name.
- c (20:7) Or "You deceived me, and I was deceived"; the verb pathah is used of seducing (Exodus 22:16).

Chapter 21

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh when King Zedekiah[a]
sent to him Pashhur son of Malchiah and the priest Zephaniah son of

Maaseiah, with this request: 2 “Inquire of Yahweh on our behalf, we
beg you, for Nebuchadrezzar[b] king of Babylon is waging war on us.
Perhaps Yahweh will deal with us in keeping with all his wonders,
and make him withdraw from us.”
3 Jeremiah answered them, “Say this to Zedekiah: 4 ‘So says Yahweh,
God of Israel: Look, I will turn back the weapons of war in your hands,
with which you are fighting the king of Babylon and the Chaldeans[c]
who are besieging you outside the walls, and I will gather them into
the heart of this city. 5 And it is I who will wage war on you, with hand
stretched out and arm strong, in rage and fury and towering wrath.
6 I will strike down those who live in this city, man and beast alike;
of a great plague they will die. 7 After that, declares Yahweh, I will
deliver Zedekiah, Judah’s king, with his officials and the populace—
whoever in this city is left over from plague, sword, and famine—over
to Nebuchadrezzar, Babylon’s king, over to their foes and those who
hunt their lives. He will cut them down with the edge of the sword,
sparing none, pitying none, showing no compassion.’
8 “And to this people you shall say, ‘So says Yahweh: Look, I am
setting before you the way of life and the way of death. 9 Anyone who
remains inside this city will perish by sword, hunger, or plague; but
anyone who walks out and gives himself up to the Chaldeans now
besieging you will survive, and come away with his life as booty.[d] 10
For I have set my face against this city for harm and not for good,
declares Yahweh; it will be handed over to Babylon’s king, and he
will burn it with fire.’
11 “And to the royal house of Judah say, ‘Hear Yahweh’s word,
12 O house of David! So says Yahweh:
Dispense justice every morning,
and rescue the robbed from the oppressor’s hand,
lest my fury break out like fire
and burn with none to put it out,
because of your evil deeds.
13 Look, I am against you, O dweller in the valley,
O rock of the plain, declares Yahweh—

you who say, “Who can swoop down on us?
Who can break into our lairs?”
14 I will call you to account as your deeds deserve, declares Yahweh;
I will light a fire in her forest,
and it will devour everything around her.’”

Notes

- a (21:1) Zedekiah (“Yahweh is righteousness”), the last king of Judah (597–586 B.C.), a son of Josiah, installed by Nebuchadnezzar (2 Kings 24:17). This Pashhur is not the Pashhur of 20:1.
- b (21:2) Nebuchadrezzar is a variant spelling of Nebuchadnezzar, closer to the Babylonian Nabû-kudurri-uṣur, “O Nabu, protect the heir”; he reigned 605–562 B.C. Jeremiah uses both spellings.
- c (21:4) The Chaldeans (Hebrew Kasdim) were the people of southern Babylonia whose dynasty ruled the Neo-Babylonian empire.
- d (21:9) That is, he will escape with nothing but his life.

Chapter 22

1 So says Yahweh: “Go down to the palace of Judah’s king and speak this word there:
2 ‘Hear Yahweh’s word, O king of Judah who sits on David’s throne —you, your servants, and your people who enter by these gates.
3 So says Yahweh: Practice justice and righteousness; rescue the robbed from the hand of the oppressor. Do no wrong or violence to the sojourner, the orphan, or the widow, and shed no innocent blood in this place.
4 For if you indeed carry out this word, then kings who sit for David on his throne will enter by the gates of this palace, riding in chariots and on horses, they and their servants and their people.
5 But if you refuse to obey these words, I swear by myself, declares Yahweh, that this palace will be turned into a ruin.’
6 For so says Yahweh concerning the palace of Judah’s king:
“You are to me like Gilead,
like the summit of Lebanon;
yet I will surely turn you into a wasteland,
towns left uninhabited.

7 I will send destroyers against you,
each with his weapons;
they will chop down your finest cedars
and throw them on the fire.
8 "Many nations will pass by this city, and each will ask his neighbor,
'Why has Yahweh treated this great city so?' 9 And they will answer,
'Because they abandoned the covenant of Yahweh their God and
bowed to other gods and served them.'"
10 Weep not for the dead man,[a] nor mourn for him;
weep rather for the one going away,
for he will never return
to see the land of his birth.
11 For so says Yahweh concerning Shallum[b] son of Josiah, king of
Judah, who reigned in place of Josiah his father and has gone away
from this place: "He will never return here;
12 in the place where they carried him captive, there he will die, and
he will see this land no more."
13 "Woe to him who builds his house without righteousness,
his upper rooms without justice,
who works his neighbor for nothing
and pays him no wage for his toil,
14 who says, 'I will build myself a large palace
with spacious upper rooms,'
so he cuts windows in it,
lines it with cedar
and paints it bright red.
15 Are you a king because you vie in cedar?[c]
Did not your father eat and drink
and do justice and righteousness?
Then it went well with him.
16 He defended the cause of the poor and needy;
then it went well.
Is not this what it means to know me?
declares Yahweh.

17 But your eyes and your heart
are set only on your unjust gain,
on shedding innocent blood,
on oppression and extortion."
18 Therefore this is what Yahweh says about Jehoiakim[d] son of Josiah,
king of Judah:
"Nobody will mourn for him by saying,
'Oh, my brother!' or 'Oh, my sister!'
Nobody will mourn for him by saying,
'Oh, master!' or 'Oh, his majesty!'
19 With a donkey's burial he will be buried,
dragged off and flung out
beyond Jerusalem's gates."[e]
20 "Go up to Lebanon and shout;
raise your voice in Bashan;
shout from the Abarim range,[f]
for all your lovers have been crushed.
21 I spoke to you in your ease,
but you said, 'I will not listen.'
This has been your way from your youth,
that you have not obeyed my voice.
22 The wind will shepherd all your shepherds,
and your lovers will go into captivity;
then you will be ashamed and disgraced
for all your wickedness.
23 You who make your home in Lebanon,
who nest high in the cedars,
what groaning[g] will be yours when the pains seize you,
throes like those of childbirth!"
24 "As I live, declares Yahweh, even if Coniah[h] son of Jehoiakim, king
of Judah, were the signet ring on my right hand, yet I would tear
you off from there, 25 and hand you over to those who want to kill
you, to those you fear, to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and to
the Chaldeans. 26 I will hurl you and the mother who bore you into
another country, where you were not born, and there you will die.

27 But to the land to which they long to return, there they will not return."
28 Is Coniah, then, a scorned and shattered jar,
a pot that pleases no one?
Why have he and his children been flung away,
tossed out into a country unknown to them?
29 O land, land, land,
hear the word of Yahweh!
30 So says Yahweh:
"Record this man as childless,
a man who will not prosper in his days;
for none of his offspring will succeed
in sitting on David's throne
and ruling again in Judah."[i]

Notes

- a (22:10) That is, King Josiah, killed at Megiddo in 609 B.C. (2 Kings 23:29).
- b (22:11) Shallum ("recompense") is the personal name of King Jehoahaz, son of Josiah, who reigned three months in 609 B.C. before Pharaoh Neco took him to Egypt (2 Kings 23:30–34).
- c (22:15) Or "because you outdo others in cedar."
- d (22:18) Jehoiakim ("Yahweh raises up"), son of Josiah, reigned 609–598 B.C. (2 Kings 23:34–24:6).
- e (22:19) 2 Kings 24:6 says only that Jehoiakim "slept with his fathers"; the fulfillment of this oracle is not described.
- f (22:20) Abarim, the mountain range east of the Dead Sea, including Mount Nebo.
- g (22:23) So the Septuagint and other ancient witnesses; the Hebrew reads "how you will be pitied" or "how favored you will be."
- h (22:24) Coniah, a short form of Jeconiah or Jehoiachin ("Yahweh establishes"), who reigned three months in 598–597 B.C. before being exiled to Babylon (2 Kings 24:8–15). In verses 24–27 the Hebrew shifts between "him" and "you."
- i (22:30) Jehoiachin had sons (1 Chronicles 3:17–18), but none reigned as king.

Chapter 23

1 "Woe to the shepherds who ruin and scatter the sheep of my pasture!" declares Yahweh. 2 Therefore so says Yahweh, God of Israel, about the shepherds who tend my people: "You have dispersed my flock and driven them off, and have not attended to them. Watch: I will attend to you for the evil of your deeds," declares Yahweh. 3 "And

I will personally round up what is left of my sheep out of every land
to which I banished them, and lead them home to their fold, where
they will bear young and multiply. 4 Over them I will set shepherds
who will tend them; no longer will they fear or be terrified, and none
will be missing," declares Yahweh.
5 "Look, days are coming," declares Yahweh,
"when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch;[a]
he will reign as king and act wisely,
and he will do justice and righteousness in the land.
6 In his days Judah will be saved,
and Israel will dwell in safety.
And this is the name by which he will be called:
'Yahweh Is Our Righteousness.'[b]
7 "Therefore, look, days are coming," declares Yahweh, "when men
will no longer say, 'By the life of Yahweh, who brought Israel's sons
up from the land of Egypt,' 8 but, 'By the life of Yahweh, who brought
up and led the offspring of Israel's house out of the northern land and
out of all the lands where I had driven them.' Then they will dwell on
their own soil."[c]
9 About the prophets:
Shattered is my heart inside me;
every bone of mine shakes;
I have become like one who is drunk,
like a fellow mastered by wine,
on account of Yahweh,
on account of his holy words.
10 For the land is full of adulterers;
because of the curse[d] the land mourns;
the pastures of the wilderness are dried up.
Their course is evil,
and their might is not right.
11 "For both prophet and priest are godless;
even in my house I have found their wickedness," declares Yahweh.
12 "So their path will become
like slippery ground in the dark;

they will be pushed and fall on it;
for I will bring disaster on them
in the year I punish them," declares Yahweh.
13 "In Samaria's prophets
I observed something distasteful:
they spoke oracles by Baal
and misled Israel my people.
14 Yet in Jerusalem's prophets
I have observed something appalling:
adultery and a life of lies;
they bolster the power of the wicked,
so that none turns back from his wickedness;
to me they are all like Sodom,
and her people like Gomorrah."
15 So Yahweh of Armies pronounces this about the prophets:
"I will make them eat wormwood
and drink water laced with poison,
for out of the prophets of Jerusalem
ungodliness has spread over the whole land."
16 So says Yahweh of Armies:
"Do not listen to the words of the prophets who prophesy to you;
they are filling you with vapor.[e]
They speak a vision from their own heart,
not from the mouth of Yahweh.
17 They keep saying to those who despise me,
'Yahweh has said, "You shall have peace"';
and to everyone who walks in the stubbornness of his heart they say,
'No calamity will come upon you.'"
18 For who has stood in the council[f] of Yahweh
to see and to hear his word?
Who has paid attention to his word and listened?
19 See, Yahweh's tempest!
Fury is unleashed,

a spinning gale;
on the heads of the wicked it will crash.
20 Yahweh's anger will not turn away
until he has carried out
the purposes of his mind.
In days to come
you will understand this fully.
21 "I never dispatched those prophets,
yet off they ran;
I never spoke to them,
yet they uttered prophecy.
22 But if they had attended my council,
they would have announced my words to my people
and turned them away from their evil ways
and evil deeds.
23 "Am I a God near at hand," declares Yahweh,
"and not a God far off?
24 Can a man hide himself in secret places
so that I cannot see him?" declares Yahweh.
"Do I not fill the heavens and the earth?" declares Yahweh.
25 "I have heard what the prophets have said who prophesy falsehood in my name, saying, 'I have dreamed, I have dreamed!' 26 How long? Is it in the heart of the prophets who prophesy falsehood, the prophets of the deceit of their own heart— 27 They intend to make my people forget my name through the dreams they tell each other, just as their ancestors forgot my name through Baal. 28 The prophet who has a dream—let him recount his dream; but the one who holds my word —let him relate my word with fidelity. What does chaff have to do with grain?" declares Yahweh. 29 "Is my word not like a fire," declares Yahweh, "and like a hammer that breaks a rock apart? 30 "Therefore look, I am against the prophets," declares Yahweh, "who take my words from one another. 31 Look, I am against the prophets," declares Yahweh, "who use their tongues and declare, 'He declares.' 32 Mark well, I am against those whose prophecies are false dreams," declares Yahweh, "who recount them and mislead my people with their false-

hoods and their wild boasting, though I never sent or commissioned them; not the slightest benefit do they bring this people," declares Yahweh.

33 "Whenever this people, or a prophet, or a priest asks you, 'What is Yahweh's load?'[g] answer them, 'You are the load, and I will throw you off,' declares Yahweh. 34 And the prophet, priest, or commoner who says, 'Yahweh's load'—that man and his house I will call to account. 35 This is what each of you should say to his neighbor and relative: 'What did Yahweh reply?' or 'What has Yahweh said?' 36 But never again bring up 'Yahweh's load,' for each man's own word becomes his load, and you twist the words of the living God, Yahweh of Armies, our God. 37 Thus you shall say to the prophet: 'What has Yahweh answered you?' or 'What has Yahweh spoken?' 38 Yet if you persist in saying, 'Yahweh's load,' then here is what Yahweh says: 'Since you use this phrase, "Yahweh's load," though I sent word to you forbidding you to say, "Yahweh's load," 39 for that reason I will indeed lift you up[h] and fling you out of my sight, you along with the city I bestowed on you and your ancestors. 40 I will lay on you a disgrace that lasts forever, a humiliation without end, never to be forgotten.'"

Notes

- a (23:5) Hebrew tsemaḥ, "sprout, shoot," a title for the coming king from David's line (33:15; Zechariah 3:8; 6:12).
- b (23:6) Hebrew Yahweh tsidqenu, perhaps a play on the name of King Zedekiah, tsidqiyyahu, "Yahweh is my righteousness." The Septuagint renders the name as "Josedec" (Brenton), a personal name.
- c (23:8) The Septuagint places verses 7–8 after verse 40 (Brenton, printed as 23:40a–b). Verses 7–8 nearly repeat 16:14–15.
- d (23:10) Or, with some ancient witnesses, "because of these things."
- e (23:16) Hebrew hevel, "breath, vapor"; they fill you with empty hopes.
- f (23:18) Hebrew sod, the council of heavenly beings around Yahweh (compare 1 Kings 22:19–22).
- g (23:33) Hebrew massaʾ means both "load, burden" and "oracle, utterance" (literally, something "lifted" by the voice). Verses 33–40 play on the double meaning. "You are the load" follows the Septuagint ("You are the burden," Brenton) and the Latin Vulgate; the standard Hebrew text reads "What load?" (ʾeth-mah-massaʾ), a difference only in word division.

- h (23:39) Hebrew nashithi naso', "I will utterly forget," is read by some Hebrew manuscripts and ancient witnesses as nasa'thi naso', "I will surely lift up," continuing the play on massa'.

Chapter 24

1 Yahweh showed me this: two baskets of figs were set in front of
Yahweh's temple. This was after Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon
had deported Jeconiah[a] son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah, from
Jerusalem, along with the officials of Judah, the skilled workers and
the metalworkers,[b] and brought them to Babylon. 2 One basket held
very fine figs, like first-ripe figs; the other basket held very bad figs,
so bad they could not be eaten. 3 Then Yahweh asked me, "What do
you see, Jeremiah?" I replied, "Figs—the good ones very good, and the
bad ones very bad, too bad to be eaten."
4 Then Yahweh's word came to me: 5 "This is what Yahweh, the God
of Israel, says: Like these good figs, I will treat as good the exiles of
Judah, whom I sent away from this place to the land of the Chaldeans.
6 I will keep my eyes on them for good and bring them back to this
land. I will build them and not tear them down; I will plant them and
not uproot them. 7 I will give them a heart to know me, that I am
Yahweh. They will be my people and I will be their God, for they will
return to me with all their heart.
8 "But like the bad figs, which are too bad to be eaten—so says Yahweh
—so will I treat Zedekiah king of Judah, his officials, the remnant of
Jerusalem left in this land, and those who live in the land of Egypt. 9 I
will make them a horror, a calamity[c] to all the kingdoms of the earth,
a reproach, a byword, a taunt, and a curse in all the places where I
drive them. 10 And I will send among them sword, famine, and plague,
until they are wiped out from the soil I gave to them and to their
fathers."

Notes

- a (24:1) Jeconiah, another form of the name Jehoiachin (see the note at 22:24). The deportation took place in 597 B.C. (2 Kings 24:10–16).
- b (24:1) Or "the smiths"; the Hebrew masger may mean "locksmith" or "fortifier."
- c (24:9) Hebrew "a horror for calamity." The Septuagint reads, "I will cause them to be dispersed into all the kingdoms of the earth" (Brenton), and lacks "calamity."

Chapter 25

1 The word that came to Jeremiah concerning all the people of Judah
in the fourth year of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah (that was
the first year of Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon),[a] 2 which Jeremiah
the prophet spoke to all the people of Judah and all the residents of
Jerusalem: 3 "From the thirteenth year of Josiah son of Amon, king
of Judah, until this day—these twenty-three years—Yahweh's word
has come to me, and I have spoken to you, early and persistently,
but you have not listened. 4 And Yahweh sent you all his servants the
prophets, early and persistently, but you did not listen or incline your
ear to hear, 5 when they said, 'Turn now, each of you, from his evil
way and his evil deeds, and dwell on the soil that Yahweh gave to you
and your fathers from of old and forever. 6 Do not go after other gods
to serve them and bow down to them, and do not provoke me with
the work of your hands; then I will do you no harm.' 7 Yet you did not
listen to me, declares Yahweh, so as to provoke me with the work of
your hands to your own harm.[b]
8 "Therefore so says Yahweh of Armies: Because you have not obeyed
my words, 9 mark this, I am summoning every northern clan, declares
Yahweh, and Nebuchadrezzar, Babylon's king, my servant,[c] and I will
lead them against this land and those who live in it, and against all the
surrounding nations. I will put them under the ban[d] and turn them
into an object of dread, of whistling, and of perpetual ruin. 10 I will
silence among them the noise of merriment and the noise of joy, the
bridegroom's voice and the bride's voice, the grinding of the hand
mill and the glow of the lamp. 11 This whole land will become a ruin
and a horror, and these nations will serve the king of Babylon seventy
years.[e] 12 Then when seventy years are completed, I will punish the
king of Babylon and that nation, declares Yahweh, for their guilt—
the land of the Chaldeans—and make it a desolation forever. 13 I will
bring upon that country everything I have said about it, everything
recorded in this book, which Jeremiah prophesied about all the
nations.[f] 14 For many nations and great kings shall enslave them also,
and I will repay them according to their deeds and the work of their
hands."[g]

15 For this is what Yahweh, Israel's God, told me: "Accept from my
hand this cup brimming with the wine of fury, and give it to every
nation I send you to, that they may drink. 16 They shall drink and
stagger and act crazed because of the sword I am sending among
them." 17 So I took the cup from Yahweh's hand and gave it to all the
nations Yahweh had sent me to, to drink: 18 Jerusalem and the towns
of Judah, its kings and its officials, to make them a ruin, a horror, a
thing to hiss at, and a curse, as it is this day; 19 Pharaoh, Egypt's king,
with his attendants, his nobles, and his whole nation; 20 all the mixed
peoples;[h] all the kings of the land of Uz;[i] all the kings of the land of
the Philistines—Ashkelon, Gaza, Ekron, and the remnant of Ashdod;
21 Edom, Moab, and the sons of Ammon; 22 all the kings of Tyre, all
the kings of Sidon, and the kings of the coastland across the sea; 23
Dedan, Tema, Buz, and all who clip the corners of their hair; 24 all the
kings of Arabia and all the kings of the mixed peoples who dwell in
the wilderness; 25 all the kings of Zimri,[j] all the kings of Elam, and
all the kings of Media; 26 and all the kings of the north, near and far,
one after another—all the kingdoms on earth. After them the king of
Sheshach[k] will drink.
27 "Then tell them, 'This is what Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel,
says: Drink, get drunk and throw up, fall and never get up again,
because of the sword I am sending among you.' 28 And if they refuse to
take the cup from your hand to drink, say to them, 'So says Yahweh
of Armies: You must drink! 29 For, consider: on the very city that bears
my name I am starting to bring disaster; and will you go scot-free?
Not scot-free will you go, for I am calling down a sword on everyone
who lives on the earth, declares Yahweh of Armies.'
30 "You, then, prophesy against them all these words, and say to them:
'Yahweh roars from on high;
from his holy dwelling he utters his voice;
he roars mightily against his pasture;
a shout like those who tread grapes
he raises against all the inhabitants of the earth.
31 The tumult reaches to the ends of the earth,
for Yahweh has a lawsuit with the nations;

he enters into judgment with all flesh;
the wicked he gives over to the sword,
declares Yahweh.'
32 "So says Yahweh of Armies:
Look, calamity goes forth
from nation to nation,
and a great storm is stirred up
from the farthest parts of the earth.
33 And those slain by Yahweh on that day will be from one end of the earth to the other end of the earth. They will not be mourned, gathered, or buried; they will be dung on the face of the ground.
34 "Wail, you shepherds, and cry out;
roll in the dust, you lords of the flock,
for your days for slaughter have come,
and you will be scattered,[l]
and you will fall like a precious vessel.
35 Flight will fail the shepherds,
and escape the lords of the flock.
36 Listen—the cry of the shepherds,
the wail of the lords of the flock!
For Yahweh is ravaging their pasture,
37 and the peaceful folds are laid waste
because of the fierce anger of Yahweh.
38 He has quit his thicket like a lion,
for their country has turned into a wasteland
before the sword of the oppressor[m]
and before his burning anger."

Notes

- a (25:1) That is, 605 B.C., the year of the battle of Carchemish (46:2). The Septuagint lacks the parenthesis (Brenton).
- b (25:7) The Septuagint lacks most of verse 7, reading only, "But you did not listen to me" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (25:9) The Septuagint lacks "and for Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon, my servant" and reads "a family from the north" (Brenton). In the shorter Greek text, the foe from the north is not named here.
- d (25:9) Hebrew ḥerem, the ban of total destruction in holy war.

- e (25:11) The seventy years are reckoned in different ways: from 605 B.C. to the fall of Babylon in 539 B.C., or from the destruction of the temple in 586 B.C. to its rebuilding in 516 B.C. (compare 29:10; 2 Chronicles 36:21; Daniel 9:2; Zechariah 1:12). The Septuagint lacks "the king of Babylon" in verse 11 and "the king of Babylon and" in verse 12 (Brenton).
- f (25:13) In the Septuagint, verse 13 ends at "written in this book," and the next words introduce the oracles against the nations, beginning with Elam (Brenton: "The Prophecies of Jeremias against the Nations of Ælam"). These oracles, which stand at chapters 46–51 in the Hebrew, follow at this point in the Greek. See the introductory note.
- g (25:14) The Septuagint lacks verse 14 (Brenton). The Greek resumes with verse 15 as chapter 32 in Brenton's numbering.
- h (25:20) Or "all the foreign people"; Hebrew ʿerev, perhaps foreign mercenaries or settlers.
- i (25:20) The Septuagint lacks "all the kings of the land of Uz" (Brenton). Uz is a region east or southeast of Israel, the home of Job (Job 1:1).
- j (25:25) Zimri is otherwise unknown; it may be a cipher like Sheshach (verse 26), or a corruption. The Septuagint lacks it (Brenton).
- k (25:26) Sheshach is a cipher for Babel (Babylon), formed by atbash, a scribal code that replaces each Hebrew letter with its counterpart from the other end of the alphabet (aleph with taw, beth with shin, and so on): b-b-l becomes sh-sh-k. See also 51:41. The Septuagint lacks this sentence (Brenton).
- l (25:34) Hebrew uncertain; some read "and I will shatter you."
- m (25:38) So some Hebrew manuscripts (compare 46:16; 50:16); the Septuagint has "the great sword" (Brenton); the standard Hebrew text reads "the oppressor's fury," with "fury" repeated in the next line.

Chapter 26

1 At the beginning of the reign of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah,[a] this word came from Yahweh: 2 "So says Yahweh: Take your stand in the court of Yahweh's house and speak to all the towns of Judah that come to bow down in Yahweh's house all the words I command you to speak to them; hold back not a word. 3 Perhaps they will listen, and each will turn from his evil way, so that I may relent of the calamity I am planning to bring on them because of their evil deeds. 4 Say to them, 'So says Yahweh: If you will not listen to me, to walk in my law that I have set before you, 5 and to heed the words of my servants the prophets whom I send to you early and persistently, though you have not listened, 6 then I will make this house like Shiloh,

and I will make this city an example of a curse for all the nations on earth.'"
7 The priests, the prophets, and all the people heard Jeremiah speaking
these words in Yahweh's house. 8 When Jeremiah had said all that
Yahweh ordered him to tell the people, the priests, the prophets and
everyone else seized him and said, "You are going to die! 9 Why did
you prophesy in Yahweh's name that this house will become like
Shiloh and this city will be destroyed and left uninhabited?" And all
the people gathered around Jeremiah in Yahweh's house.
10 When the officials of Judah heard of these things, they went up
from the king's palace to Yahweh's house and took their seats at the
entrance of the New Gate of Yahweh's house. 11 Then the priests and
the prophets told the officials and everyone else, "This man deserves
the death penalty, since he has prophesied against this city, as you
yourselves have heard."
12 Jeremiah then addressed all the officials and the whole populace: "It
was Yahweh who sent me to prophesy against this house and this city
every word you have heard. 13 So now, mend your conduct and your
actions, and heed the voice of Yahweh your God; then Yahweh will
think better of the disaster he has decreed for you. 14 As for me, I am
in your power; do to me whatever you think is good and right. 15 Only
know for certain that if you put me to death, you will bring innocent
blood on yourselves, on this city, and on its residents, for in truth
Yahweh sent me to you to speak all these words in your hearing."
16 At that the officials and all the populace told the priests and
prophets, "No death sentence is due this man, since it is in the name
of Yahweh our God that he has addressed us."
17 And some of the elders of the land rose up and spoke to the whole
assembly of the people:
18 "Micah of Moresheth[b] was a prophet in the time of Hezekiah king
of Judah. He said to all the people of Judah, 'This is what Yahweh of
Armies says:

Zion will be plowed like a field;

19 Did Hezekiah king of Judah and all Judah put him to death? Did he
not fear Yahweh and entreat the favor of Yahweh, and did not Yahweh

relent of the calamity he had pronounced against them? But we are about to bring great calamity on ourselves."
20 There was also a man who prophesied in Yahweh's name, Uriah son of Shemaiah from Kiriath-jearim. He prophesied against this city and this land in words like all those of Jeremiah. 21 King Jehoiakim, along with all his fighting men and every official, heard what he said, and the king set out to have him killed. Uriah got word of it; in fear he ran off and reached Egypt. 22 Then King Jehoiakim sent men to Egypt—Elnathan son of Achbor[c] and others with him. 23 These fetched Uriah back from Egypt and delivered him to King Jehoiakim, who cut him down with a sword and flung his body among the burial plots of the common folk. 24 Yet Ahikam son of Shaphan[d] stood by Jeremiah and protected him, so that he was not handed over to the mob to be killed.

Notes

- a (26:1) That is, about 609 B.C. This chapter narrates the occasion and outcome of the temple sermon given more fully in 7:1–15.
- b (26:18) Micah of Moresheth, the prophet whose book stands among the Twelve; the quotation is Micah 3:12. Micah means "Who is like Yahweh?"
- c (26:22) Elnathan ("God has given") was perhaps the father of Nehushta, Jehoiachin's mother (2 Kings 24:8). The Septuagint lacks "Elnathan son of Achbor and others with him" (Brenton).
- d (26:24) Ahikam son of Shaphan, an official under Josiah (2 Kings 22:12) and father of Gedaliah, later governor of Judah (40:5).

Chapter 27

1 At the beginning of the reign of Zedekiah[a] son of Josiah, king of Judah, this word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 2 This is what Yahweh told me: "Fashion for yourself thongs and wooden yoke bars, and set them upon your neck. 3 Then dispatch them[b] to Edom's king, Moab's king, the Ammonites' king, Tyre's king, and Sidon's king, through the emissaries who have arrived in Jerusalem to meet Zedekiah, Judah's king. 4 Give them a charge for their lords: 'Thus speaks Yahweh of Armies, Israel's God—tell this to your lords: 5 By my great power and outstretched arm I made the earth, together with the people and animals on it, and I give it to anyone I choose. 6 And now I have given all these lands into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar

king of Babylon, my servant; even the beasts of the field I have given him to serve him. 7 All the nations shall serve him and his son and his grandson, until the time of his own land comes; then many nations and great kings shall make him their servant.[c] 8 "If any nation or kingdom refuses to serve Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and refuses to bend its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon, I will punish that nation with sword, famine and plague, declares Yahweh, until I have finished them off through him. 9 So pay no heed to your prophets or your diviners, to your dreamers,[d] your fortune-tellers, or your sorcerers, who keep assuring you, "You will never be subject to Babylon's king." 10 A falsehood is what they prophesy to you, and it will only get you removed far from your homeland; I will banish you, and you will be lost. 11 But the nation that brings its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon and serves him, I will leave on its own soil, declares Yahweh, to till it and dwell in it.'"

12 To Zedekiah king of Judah I spoke in the same way: "Bring your necks under the yoke of the king of Babylon, and serve him and his people, and live. 13 Why must you and your people perish by sword, starvation, and pestilence, as Yahweh has threatened against every nation that refuses to be subject to Babylon's king?[e] 14 Do not listen to the words of the prophets who keep telling you, 'You shall not serve the king of Babylon,' for it is a lie they prophesy to you. 15 I never sent them, declares Yahweh; yet they prophesy lies under my name, and so I will banish you and you will be lost, both you and the prophets prophesying to you."

16 Next I addressed the priests and this whole people: "So says Yahweh: Pay no heed to what your prophets prophesy to you, 'Look, any day now the furnishings of Yahweh's house will be returned from Babylon,' for a falsehood is what they prophesy to you. 17 Do not listen to them. Serve the king of Babylon and live. Why should this city become a ruin?[f] 18 If they are prophets, and if Yahweh's word is with them, let them now intercede with Yahweh of Armies, that the vessels left in Yahweh's house, in the palace of the king of Judah, and in Jerusalem may not go to Babylon. 19 For Yahweh of Armies has spoken about the columns,[g] the bronze sea, the wheeled bases, and whatever

other furnishings remain in this city, 20 which Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon did not take when he carried Jeconiah son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah, into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon, with all the nobles of Judah and Jerusalem— 21 so says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel, concerning the vessels left in Yahweh's house, in the palace of the king of Judah, and in Jerusalem:[h] 22 'To Babylon they shall be carried, and there they shall remain until the day I attend to them, declares Yahweh. Then I will bring them up and restore them to this place.'"

Notes

- a (27:1) So a few Hebrew manuscripts and the Syriac (compare verses 3 and 12 and 28:1); the standard Hebrew text reads "Jehoiakim," probably by copying from 26:1. The Septuagint lacks verse 1 (Brenton). The likely date is 594–593 B.C. (28:1).
- b (27:3) Hebrew "send them." Jeremiah's symbolic yoke is described in 28:10–11.
- c (27:7) The Septuagint lacks verse 7 (Brenton).
- d (27:9) Hebrew "your dreams."
- e (27:13) The Septuagint lacks verse 13 (Brenton). Its text of verses 12–22 is markedly shorter throughout.
- f (27:17) The Septuagint lacks verse 17 (Brenton).
- g (27:19) The two bronze pillars, Jachin and Boaz, the great bronze basin called "the sea," and the wheeled stands made for Solomon's temple (1 Kings 7:15–39). The Septuagint lacks this list, reading only "And as for the remaining vessels" (Brenton).
- h (27:21) The Septuagint lacks verse 21 and the last sentence of verse 22, ending, "they shall go into Babylon, says the Lord" (Brenton, modernized).

Chapter 28

1 In that same year, at the start of the reign of Zedekiah king of Judah, in the fourth year,[a] in the fifth month (in July–August),[b] the prophet Hananiah[c] son of Azzur, from Gibeon, addressed me in Yahweh's house before the priests and all the people: 2 "So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: I have broken the yoke of Babylon's king. 3 Within two years' time I will bring back to this place all the furnishings of Yahweh's house that Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon removed from this place and carried to Babylon. 4 I will also bring back to this place Jeconiah son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah, and all the exiles of Judah who went to Babylon, declares Yahweh, for I will smash the yoke of the king of Babylon."

5 Then Jeremiah the prophet answered Hananiah the prophet in the
presence of the priests and of all the people standing in Yahweh's
house. 6 Jeremiah the prophet said, "Amen! May Yahweh do so! May
Yahweh fulfill the words you have prophesied and bring back from
Babylon to this place the furnishings of Yahweh's house and all the
exiles. 7 Nevertheless, give ear to this word that I am declaring to you
and to the whole people listening: 8 The prophets who lived before
you and me long ago prophesied war, disaster and plague against
many countries and great kingdoms. 9 As for the prophet who proph-
esies peace, when that prophet's word comes to pass, then it will be
known that Yahweh truly sent him."
10 Then the prophet Hananiah removed the yoke bar from the prophet
Jeremiah's neck and broke it. 11 And Hananiah spoke before all the
people: "So says Yahweh: Just so will I break the yoke of Nebuchad-
nezzar king of Babylon from the neck of all the nations within two
years' time." And Jeremiah the prophet went his way.
12 Some time after the prophet Hananiah had broken the yoke bar
that was on the prophet Jeremiah's neck, Yahweh's word came to
Jeremiah: 13 "Go and tell Hananiah, 'So says Yahweh: Yoke bars of
wood you have broken, but in their place you will make[d] yoke bars
of iron. 14 For so says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: A yoke of iron
I have put on the neck of all these nations to serve Nebuchadnezzar
king of Babylon, and they shall serve him; even the beasts of the
field I have given him.'" 15 Jeremiah the prophet then told Hananiah
the prophet, "Hear me, Hananiah! Yahweh never sent you, and you
have led this people to rely on falsehood. 16 Therefore so says Yahweh:
Look, I am sending you off[e] from the face of the earth. This very year
you will die, because you have spoken rebellion against Yahweh." 17
And Hananiah the prophet died that same year, in the seventh month
(in September–October).[f]

Notes

- a (28:1) That is, 594–593 B.C. The Septuagint reads simply "in the fourth year of Zedekiah king of Judah" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (28:1) Hebrew "the fifth month," Av.

- c (28:1) Hananiah, "Yahweh has been gracious." The Septuagint calls him "the false prophet" (Brenton), here and elsewhere in the chapter.
- d (28:13) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "I will make" (Brenton: "but I will make instead of them yokes of iron").
- e (28:16) Hebrew meshallḥakha, a play on the verb "send" (shalaḥ) in verse 15: Yahweh did not send Hananiah as a prophet, but he will send him off the earth.
- f (28:17) Hebrew "the seventh month," Tishri, about two months after the confrontation of verse 1. The Septuagint lacks "that same year" (Brenton).

Chapter 29

1 These are the words of the letter that Jeremiah the prophet sent
from Jerusalem to the surviving elders of the exiles, to the priests,
the prophets, and all the people whom Nebuchadnezzar had carried
into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon. 2 This was after King Jeconiah
had left Jerusalem, along with the queen mother, the court officials,[a]
Judah's and Jerusalem's leaders, and the craftsmen and metalworkers.
3 The letter went by the hand of Elasah son of Shaphan and Gemariah
son of Hilkiah, whom Zedekiah king of Judah dispatched to Babylon,
to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon. It read:
4 "So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel, to all the exiles whom
I have exiled from Jerusalem to Babylon: 5 Build houses and settle
in them; plant gardens and eat what they produce. 6 Take wives
and father sons and daughters; take wives for your sons, and give
your daughters to husbands, that they may bear sons and daughters.
Multiply there; do not dwindle. 7 And seek the welfare[b] of the city
where I have exiled you, and pray to Yahweh on its behalf, for in its
welfare will be your welfare. 8 For so says Yahweh of Armies, God of
Israel: Do not let the prophets and the diviners among you deceive
you, and pay no attention to the dreams you have them dream,[c] 9 for it
is a lie they are prophesying to you in my name. I did not send them,
declares Yahweh.
10 "For so says Yahweh: Only when seventy years for Babylon are
completed will I attend to you, and I will fulfill for you my good
word, to bring you back to this place. 11 For I know the plans I have
for you, declares Yahweh—plans for well-being and not for disaster,
to give you a future with hope.[d] 12 Then you will cry out to me; you

will come and pray to me, and I will hear you. 13 You will seek me
and find me, when you search for me with all your heart. 14 Found by
you I will be, declares Yahweh; I will turn your captivity around and
collect you out of every nation and every place to which I banished
you, declares Yahweh, and lead you home to the place from which I
sent you into exile.[e]
15 "You have claimed, 'Yahweh has appointed prophets for us in
Babylon'— 16 this is what Yahweh says about the king who sits on
David's throne and about all the people who live in this city, your
relatives who did not go into exile with you:[f] 17 So says Yahweh of
Armies: Look, I am sending among them sword, famine, and plague,
and I will make them like rotten figs, too bad to be eaten. 18 I will
pursue them with sword, famine, and plague, and I will make them
a horror to all the kingdoms of the earth, a curse, a desolation,
a thing to hiss at, and a reproach among all the nations where I
have driven them, 19 because they did not heed my words, declares
Yahweh, which I sent to them by my servants the prophets, early
and persistently; and you too would not listen, declares Yahweh. 20
Hear, then, Yahweh's word, all you exiles whom I sent away from
Jerusalem to Babylon: 21 This is what Yahweh of Armies, the God of
Israel, says about Ahab son of Kolaiah and Zedekiah son of Maaseiah,
who are prophesying lies to you in my name: Look, I will deliver them
to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, and you will see him execute
them. 22 Because of them, all the exiles from Judah in Babylon will use
this curse: 'May Yahweh make you like Zedekiah and Ahab, whom
the king of Babylon roasted over a fire,'[g] 23 For they committed folly
in Israel, sleeping with their neighbors' wives and speaking in my
name falsehoods I never charged them to speak. I know it, and I bear
witness, declares Yahweh."
24 To Shemaiah the Nehelamite[h] you shall say: 25 "So says Yahweh of
Armies, God of Israel: Because you have sent letters in your own
name to all the people in Jerusalem, to Zephaniah son of Maaseiah
the priest, and to all the priests, saying, 26 'Yahweh has appointed you
priest in place of Jehoiada the priest, to be in charge in Yahweh's
house of every madman who acts like a prophet, and to put such

a person in the stocks and neck irons. 27 Now then, why have you
not rebuked Jeremiah of Anathoth, who is prophesying to you? 28 For
he has sent to us in Babylon, saying, “It will be long; build houses
and settle in them, and plant gardens and eat what they produce.”’”
29 Zephaniah the priest read this letter in the hearing of Jeremiah the
prophet. 30 Then Yahweh’s word came to Jeremiah: 31 “Send word to
all the exiles: ‘So says Yahweh about Shemaiah the Nehelamite: Since
Shemaiah prophesied to you though I never sent him, and led you
to rely on falsehood, 32 therefore so says Yahweh: Look, I will punish
Shemaiah the Nehelamite and his offspring. He shall have no man
dwelling among this people to see the good I will do to my people,
declares Yahweh, for he has spoken rebellion against Yahweh.’”

Notes

- a (29:2) Hebrew sarisim, often “eunuchs,” but also a general title for court officials.
- b (29:7) Hebrew shalom, “peace, welfare, wholeness,” three times in this verse.
- c (29:8) Hebrew “your dreams that you cause to be dreamed”; the Septuagint reads “your dreams which you dream” (Brenton, modernized).
- d (29:11) Hebrew “an end (aḥarith) and a hope,” that is, a hopeful future.
- e (29:14) The Septuagint lacks most of verse 14, reading only “And I will appear to you” (Brenton).
- f (29:16) The Septuagint lacks verses 16–20 (Brenton).
- g (29:22) Hebrew qalam, “roasted,” a play on qelalah, “curse,” and on the name Kolaiah (verse 21).
- h (29:24) Nehelamite, perhaps “of Nehelam,” an unknown place; it may also suggest ḥalam, “to dream.”

Chapter 30

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 2 “So says Yahweh,
God of Israel: Write down in a scroll[a] every word I have spoken to
you. 3 For look, days are coming, declares Yahweh, when I will turn
back the captivity of my people, Israel and Judah, says Yahweh, and
lead them home to the land I gave their fathers, and they will take
possession of it.”
4 These are the words Yahweh spoke concerning Israel and Judah:
5 So says Yahweh:

“A cry of panic we have heard,
of dread, and no peace.

6 Ask now and consider:
can a male give birth?
Why then do I see every man
with his hands on his loins like a woman in labor,
every face turned ashen?
7 Alas! For that day is great,
with none like it;
a season of distress it is for Jacob,
yet out of it he will be saved.
8 "On that day, declares Yahweh of Armies,
I will snap the yoke from off your[b] neck,
and your thongs I will tear apart,
and foreigners will no longer make him their slave.
9 Instead they will serve Yahweh their God
and David their king,
whom I will raise up for them.
10 "But you, fear not, O Jacob my servant, declares Yahweh,
and do not lose heart, O Israel;
for look, I will rescue you from far away,
your offspring from the land of their captivity.
Jacob will come home and be at rest, untroubled,
with none to make him afraid.
11 For beside you I stand, declares Yahweh, to deliver you;
an utter finish I will make of every nation
where I dispersed you,
yet you I will not utterly finish.
With fairness I will discipline you;
unpunished I will not let you go.[c]
12 "For so says Yahweh:
Your fracture cannot be mended;
your wound is past cure.
13 No one pleads your case;
for a sore there is remedy,
but no new flesh for you.[d]

14 All your lovers have forgotten you;
they do not seek you out;
for I struck you with an enemy's blow,
the chastisement of a cruel one,
because your guilt is great,
because your sins are many.
15 Why cry out over your fracture,
your pain past cure?
Because your guilt is great,
because your sins are many,
I have done these things to you.[e]
16 So everyone who devours you will be devoured,
and all your enemies will be taken into exile;
those who rob you will themselves be robbed,
and all who plunder you I will give over to plunder.
17 For fresh skin I will grow over you,
and of your wounds I will cure you, declares Yahweh,
since "Castaway" they have named you:
"That is Zion, whom nobody seeks!"
18 "So says Yahweh:
Look, I will turn back the captivity of Jacob's tents
and have compassion on his dwellings;
the city will be rebuilt on its mound,[f]
and the citadel will stand where it rightly belongs.
19 From them will come songs of thanksgiving
and the sound of those who make merry.
I will multiply them, and they will not be few;
I will bring them honor, and they will not be small.
20 His sons will be as in days of old,
and his congregation will be established before me,
and I will punish all who oppress him.
21 Their leader will come from among them,
their ruler will arise from their own number.
I will let him come close and approach me,

for who would risk his life
to approach me? declares Yahweh.
22 And you will be my people,
and I will be your God."[g]
23 Look, the storm of Yahweh!
Fury goes out,
a sweeping tempest;
it will whirl down on the head of the wicked.
24 The burning anger of Yahweh will not turn back
until he has carried out and accomplished
the purposes of his heart.
In the latter days
you will understand this.[h]

Notes

- a (30:2) Chapters 30–31 are often called "the Book of Consolation."
- b (30:8) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "their neck" (Brenton).
- c (30:11) The Septuagint lacks verses 10–11 (Brenton); they appear again at 46:27–28, where the Septuagint has them.
- d (30:13) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain.
- e (30:15) The Septuagint lacks verse 15 (Brenton).
- f (30:18) Hebrew tel, a mound of ruins built up from earlier settlements.
- g (30:22) The Septuagint lacks verse 22 (Brenton).
- h (30:24) Verses 23–24 nearly repeat 23:19–20.

Chapter 31

1 "In that time, declares Yahweh, I will be God to all the clans of Israel,
and they shall be a people to me."
2 So says Yahweh:
"Favor in the wilderness was found
by a people escaped from the sword;
Israel went on its way to find rest.[a]
3 From far off Yahweh appeared to me:[b]
'With a love of old ages I have loved you;
that is why I have drawn you on with steadfast kindness.
4 Again I will build you, and built you shall be,
O virgin Israel!

Again you will take up your tambourines
and go forth in the dance of merrymakers.
5 Again you will plant vineyards
on Samaria's hills;
the planters will plant
and enjoy the fruit.
6 For a day comes when watchmen will call out
on the hill country of Ephraim,
"Up, let us go to Zion,
to Yahweh our God!""
7 For this is what Yahweh says:
"Sing joyfully for Jacob;
shout for the foremost of the nations;
proclaim it, praise and say,
'Yahweh, rescue your people,
the survivors of Israel!'
8 Look, I am bringing them from the north country
and gathering them from the far reaches of the earth,
among them the blind and the lame,
the woman with child and the one in labor together;
a great throng, they will return here.
9 Weeping they shall come;
amid their supplications I will conduct them;
by brooks of water I will walk them,
along a straight track where none trips;
for to Israel I am father,
and Ephraim—my firstborn he is.
10 "Nations, listen to Yahweh's word
and tell it in the distant coastlands;
say, 'The one who scattered Israel will gather them
and watch over them like a shepherd over his flock.'
11 For Yahweh has ransomed Jacob
and redeemed him from a hand too strong for him.
12 They will come and shout for joy on Zion's height
and stream toward the goodness of Yahweh—

toward grain, new wine, and oil,
and the young of flock and herd;
their life will be like a well-watered garden,
and they will languish no more.
13 Then the virgin will rejoice in the dance,
young men and old together;
I will turn their mourning into gladness;
I will comfort them and give them joy in place of sorrow.
14 I will drench the priests' souls with abundance,
and my people will be filled with my goodness, declares Yahweh."
15 So says Yahweh:
"A voice in Ramah is heard,
lamentation, bitter weeping:
Rachel[c] weeping over her children,
refusing to be comforted over her children,
because they are no more."
16 So says Yahweh:
"Hold back your voice from weeping
and your eyes from tears,
for there is a reward for your labor, declares Yahweh;
they will return from the land of the enemy.
17 There is hope for your future, declares Yahweh;
your children will return to their own territory.
18 "Clearly I have heard Ephraim rocking with grief:
'You disciplined me, and I took the discipline,
like a calf untrained to the yoke.
Bring me back, that I may come back,
for you are Yahweh my God.
19 After I turned away, I felt regret;
after I came to understand, I beat my chest;
I was ashamed and humiliated,
because I carried the disgrace of my youth.'
20 Is Ephraim a dear son to me?
A child of delight?
For as often as I speak against him,

I remember him still.
Therefore my inmost parts yearn for him;
I will surely have compassion on him, declares Yahweh.
21 Plant waymarks for yourself;
erect guideposts;
fix your thoughts on the causeway,
the route you once traveled.
Turn back, virgin Israel;
turn back to these towns of yours.
22 How long will you waver,
O faithless daughter?
For Yahweh has created a new thing in the land:
a female surrounds a man."[d]
23 So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: "Once more they will use this saying in the land of Judah and in its cities, when I restore their fortunes:
'Yahweh bless you, abode of righteousness,
O holy mountain!'
24 And Judah and all its cities will dwell in it together, the farmers and those who wander with flocks.
25 For the exhausted soul I will revive, and each drooping soul I will fill full."
26 Upon this I woke and saw; pleasant to me my sleep had been.[e]
27 "Look, days are coming, declares Yahweh, when I will sow the house of Israel and the house of Judah with the seed of man and the seed of beast.
28 And as I watched over them to uproot and to tear down, to overthrow, to destroy, and to bring harm, so I will watch over them to build and to plant, declares Yahweh.
29 In those days they will no longer say,
'The fathers ate sour grapes,
and the children's teeth are set on edge.'
30 Instead, everyone will die for his own sin; whoever eats sour grapes will have his own teeth set on edge.

31 “Look, the days are coming, declares Yahweh, when I will make
a new covenant[f] with the people of Israel and the people of Judah
— 32 unlike the covenant I cut with their ancestors when I took hold
of their hand to lead them out from Egypt’s land—that covenant of
mine they shattered, even though I was master over them,[g] declares
Yahweh. 33 For this is the covenant I will cut with the house of Israel
after those days, declares Yahweh: I will set my law[h] within them,
and upon their heart I will write it; and I will be their God, and they
shall be my people. 34 And no longer will each one teach his neighbor
and each his brother, saying, ‘Know Yahweh,’ for they shall all know
me, from the least of them to the greatest, declares Yahweh; for I will
forgive their guilt, and their sin I will remember no more.”
35 So says Yahweh,[i]
giver of the sun to light the daytime,
of the statutes of moon and stars to light the night,
who churns the sea till its breakers thunder—
Yahweh of Armies his name is:
36 “If this fixed order departs
from before me, declares Yahweh,
then also the offspring of Israel will cease
from being a nation before me for all time.”
37 So says Yahweh:
“If the heavens above can be measured,
and the foundations of the earth below be searched out,
then I too will reject all the offspring of Israel
for all they have done, declares Yahweh.”
38 “Look, the days are coming,[j] declares Yahweh, when Yahweh’s city
will be rebuilt, stretching from the Tower of Hananel to the Corner
Gate. 39 Further still the measuring cord will run, directly to Gareb’s
hill, then bend around toward Goah. 40 The entire vale of carcasses
and ashes[k] and every terrace down to the Kidron gorge, as far as the
Horse Gate’s corner on the east, shall be holiness to Yahweh. Never
again will it be plucked up or thrown down.”

Notes

- a (31:2) The Hebrew of verse 2 is difficult; it may refer to the exodus generation. The Septuagint reads "I found him warm in the wilderness with them that were slain with the sword" (Brenton).
- b (31:3) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "to him" (Brenton: "The Lord appeared to him from far").
- c (31:15) Rachel, "ewe." The wife of Jacob and mother of Joseph and Benjamin, buried near Ramah (compare 1 Samuel 10:2); here she mourns her descendants carried away. Matthew 2:18 cites this verse.
- d (31:22) The meaning of "a female surrounds a man" is uncertain and much debated. The Septuagint reads very differently: "for the Lord has created safety for a new plantation: men shall go about in safety" (Brenton). Item for scholarly review.
- e (31:26) Perhaps the prophet's words on waking from a revelatory dream.
- f (31:31) Hebrew "cut a covenant," the idiom for making a covenant, perhaps from the ritual of cutting animals (compare 34:18). The Septuagint reads "make a new covenant" (Brenton). Hebrews 8:8–12 cites verses 31–34 from the Greek.
- g (31:32) Hebrew ba'alti, "I was husband (or master)"; the Septuagint reads "and I disregarded them" (Brenton), as in Hebrews 8:9.
- h (31:33) Hebrew torah, "instruction, law."
- i (31:35) The Septuagint places verse 37 before verses 35–36 (Brenton 38:35–37).
- j (31:38) The written Hebrew text has only "Look, days"; "coming" is supplied by the Hebrew margin (the Qere) and the ancient versions.
- k (31:40) Hebrew "valley of the corpses and the fat ashes," probably the Valley of Ben-hinnom (compare 7:31–32).

Chapter 32

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh in the tenth
year of Zedekiah king of Judah, which was the eighteenth year of
Nebuchadrezzar.[a] 2 At that time the army of Babylon's king was be-
sieging Jerusalem, and Jeremiah the prophet was shut up in the court
of the guard, which was in the palace of Judah's king. 3 For Zedekiah
king of Judah had confined him, saying, "Why do you prophesy, 'So
says Yahweh: Look, I am handing this city over to the king of Babylon,
and he will capture it; 4 Zedekiah king of Judah will not escape from
the Chaldeans' grip but will certainly be handed over to Babylon's
king, and will speak with him mouth to mouth and see him eye to
eye; 5 to Babylon he will lead Zedekiah, and there he will remain until
I attend to him, declares Yahweh; though you fight the Chaldeans,
you will not succeed'?"[b]

6 Jeremiah said, “Yahweh’s word came to me: 7 ‘Look, Hanamel son
of Shallum your uncle is coming to you to say, “Buy for yourself my
field in Anathoth, for yours is the right of redemption to buy it.”’ 8
Then Hanamel my cousin came to me, as Yahweh had said, in the
court of the guard, and said to me, ‘Buy my field in Anathoth, in the
land of Benjamin, for the right of possession and of redemption is
yours; buy it for yourself.’ Then I knew that this was Yahweh’s word. 9
“The Anathoth field I therefore purchased from Hanamel, my uncle’s
son, and for it I weighed him out roughly seven ounces[c] of silver. 10 I
signed the deed, sealed it, called in witnesses, and weighed the silver
on scales. 11 Next I took the purchase document—the copy sealed up,
holding the stipulations and terms, along with the copy left unsealed
— 12 and handed this document over to Baruch[d] son of Neriah son of
Mahseiah while Hanamel my uncle’s son looked on, together with
the witnesses whose names were on the document and every Judean
seated within the guard’s courtyard. 13 And before their eyes I charged
Baruch: 14 ‘So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: These documents
—the sealed bill of sale and the unsealed one—take them and place
them inside a clay jar,[e] that they may endure for a long time. 15 For
this is what Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: People will
once more buy houses, fields and vineyards in this land.’
16 “After I had given the deed of purchase to Baruch son of Neriah, I
prayed to Yahweh: 17 ‘Ah, Lord Yahweh! Look, it is you who made the
heavens and the earth by your great power and by your outstretched
arm; nothing is too wondrous for you. 18 You show steadfast love to
thousands, yet repay the guilt of fathers into the lap of their children
after them, O great and mighty God, whose name is Yahweh of
Armies, 19 great in counsel and mighty in deed, whose eyes are open
to all the ways of mankind, to give each according to his ways and
according to the fruit of his deeds. 20 Signs and marvels you worked
in Egypt’s land, and still today, both in Israel and across humankind,
and won for yourself renown, as is plain today. 21 You brought your
people Israel out of the land of Egypt with signs and wonders, with a
strong hand and an outstretched arm, and with great terror. 22 And you
gave them this land, which you swore to their fathers to give them, a

land flowing with milk and honey. 23 Enter they did, and seize it they did, yet to your voice they paid no heed and in your instruction they did not walk; of everything you ordered them to do, not one thing they did. So you have caused all this disaster to meet them. 24 Look, siege ramps have been built up to the city to capture it, and because of sword, famine and plague the city has been handed over to the Chaldeans who attack it. What you said has happened, and you see it for yourself. 25 And yet you, Lord Yahweh, told me, "Buy the field with silver and have witnesses present," though the Chaldeans are about to take the city.'"

26 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah: 27 "Look, I am Yahweh, the God of all flesh. Is anything too wondrous for me? 28 Therefore so says Yahweh: Look, I am handing this city to the Chaldeans and to Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon, and he will take it. 29 The Chaldeans who fight against this city will come and set this city on fire and burn it, with the houses on whose roofs they burned incense to Baal and poured out drink offerings to other gods, to provoke me. 30 For from their youth onward Israel's sons and Judah's sons have been doing only what is wrong in my eyes; Israel's sons have only been vexing me with what their hands have made, declares Yahweh.[f] 31 From the day it was built until today this city has stirred up my anger and fury, so I am going to remove it from my presence, 32 on account of every wrong done by Israel's sons and Judah's sons to vex me—they and their kings, officials, priests, and prophets, Judah's men and Jerusalem's residents alike. 33 They turned to me the back and not the face; though I taught them early and persistently, they did not listen to accept correction. 34 They set up their detestable idols inside the house that bears my name and made it unclean. 35 Baal's shrines they erected in the Ben-hinnom ravine, making sons and daughters of theirs cross through fire for Molech,[g] something I never ordered, which never once came into my thoughts—that they should commit this abhorrent act and so lead Judah into sin.

36 "So now this is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says about this city, which you say 'has been handed over to the king of Babylon through sword, famine and plague': 37 Look, I will gather them from

every country where I scattered them in my anger, rage and great fury; I will return them to this place and make them live securely. 38 They shall be my people, and I will be their God. 39 One heart and one path I will grant them, so that they revere me always, to their benefit and the benefit of their descendants following them. 40 An everlasting covenant I will cut with them: never will I turn aside from doing them good, and reverence for me I will place within their hearts, so they do not depart from me. 41 It will be my joy to do good to them, and I will plant them in this land faithfully, with all my heart and soul. 42 For this is what Yahweh says: Just as I brought all this great disaster on this people, so I will bring on them all the good I am promising. 43 Fields will be bought in this land, which you say 'is a wasteland, with no people or animals, and has been handed over to the Chaldeans.' 44 People will buy fields with silver and sign, seal and witness deeds, in the territory of Benjamin, in the area around Jerusalem, in the towns of Judah, in the hill country, in the foothills and in the Negev; for I will restore their fortunes, declares Yahweh."

Notes

- a (32:1) That is, 588–587 B.C., during the final siege of Jerusalem.
- b (32:5) The Septuagint ends the verse "and Zedekiah shall go into Babylon, and dwell there" (Brenton 39:5), lacking the rest.
- c (32:9) Hebrew "seventeen shekels," about 195 grams.
- d (32:12) Baruch, "blessed." Neriah, "Yahweh is my lamp." Mahseiah, "Yahweh is a refuge." Baruch was Jeremiah's scribe and companion (chapters 36, 43, 45). A clay seal impression reading "Berekyahu son of Neriyahu the scribe" has been reported, but its authenticity is disputed. Item for scholarly review.
- e (32:14) Hebrew "a vessel of clay," the kind of jar in which documents were kept.
- f (32:30) The Septuagint lacks the second half of verse 30 (Brenton 39:30).
- g (32:35) Or "to the king." Hebrew molekh, a deity or rite of child sacrifice; the Septuagint reads "to king Moloch" (Brenton).

Chapter 33

1 A second time Yahweh's word reached Jeremiah, while he remained shut in within the guard's courtyard: 2 "So says Yahweh, who makes it,[a] Yahweh who shapes it to set it firm—Yahweh is his name: 3 Call to me, and I will answer you and tell you great things, things fenced off,[b] that you have not known. 4 For so says Yahweh, God of Israel,

about the houses of this city and the houses of Judah's kings that are pulled down to make a defense against the siege ramps and the sword: 5 They are coming to fight the Chaldeans and fill the houses[c] with the dead bodies of people I struck down in my anger and fury, for I have turned my face away from this city because of all their wickedness. 6 Look, I will bring to it new flesh and healing; I will heal them and uncover for them a wealth of peace and faithfulness. 7 I will turn back the captivity of Judah and the captivity of Israel and build them up as at the first. 8 I will purify them from all the guilt by which they sinned against me, and pardon all the guilt by which they sinned and rebelled against me. 9 And this city shall be to me a name of joy, a praise and a glory before all the nations of the earth who hear of all the good I do for them; they will tremble and quake over all the good and all the peace I provide for it.

10 "So says Yahweh: Yet again there will sound out in this place—of which you keep saying, 'Wasteland, bare of human and animal'—in Judah's towns and along Jerusalem's deserted lanes, void of human, of resident, of animal—

11 the sound of gladness and the sound of joy, the voice of bridegroom and the voice of bride, the voice of those who say,

'Give thanks to Yahweh of Armies,
for Yahweh is good,
for his steadfast love endures forever!'

as they bring thank offerings into Yahweh's house. For I will turn back the captivity of the land as at the first, says Yahweh.

12 "This is what Yahweh of Armies says: In this place, now a wasteland with no people or animals, and in all its towns, shepherds will once again let their flocks rest in pastures. 13 In the towns of the hill country, of the lowland, and of the Negev, in the land of Benjamin, around Jerusalem, and in Judah's towns, flocks will again pass under the hands of the one who counts them, says Yahweh.

14 "Look, days are coming, declares Yahweh,[d] when I will fulfill the good word I spoke to the house of Israel and the house of Judah. 15 In those days and at that time I will make sprout for David a righteous Branch,[e] and he will execute justice and righteousness in the land. 16

In those days Judah will be saved and Jerusalem will dwell securely,
and this is what she will be called: 'Yahweh Our Righteousness.'[f] 17 For
so says Yahweh: David shall never lack a man sitting on the throne
of the house of Israel, 18 nor shall the Levite priests ever be short of
a man in my presence, presenting whole burnt offerings, sending up
grain offerings in smoke, and preparing sacrifices every day."
19 Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah: 20 "So says Yahweh: Were you
able to annul my covenant of the daytime and my covenant of the
night, so that daytime and night no longer arrive in their season, 21
then my covenant with my servant David could also be broken, so
that he would have no son to rule on his throne, and my covenant
with the Levitical priests who serve me. 22 The stars of the sky cannot
be counted, nor can the sand on the seashore be measured; in the
same way I will increase the descendants of my servant David and
the Levites who serve me."
23 Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah: 24 "Have you not observed what
this people have said: 'The two clans[g] that Yahweh chose, he has
rejected them'? So they despise my people, as though they were no
longer a nation in their sight. 25 So says Yahweh: Unless I fixed my
covenant of daytime and night, and appointed the statutes governing
heaven and earth, 26 then I would also reject the descendants of Jacob
and my servant David, and would not choose rulers from his line to
rule Abraham's, Isaac's and Jacob's descendants. But I will restore
their fortunes and have compassion on them."

Notes

- a (33:2) So the Hebrew, "who makes it" (that is, who brings his plan to pass). The Septuagint reads "who made the earth and formed it" (Brenton).
- b (33:3) Hebrew betsuroth, "fortified, inaccessible"; some Hebrew manuscripts read netsuroth, "hidden."
- c (33:5) Hebrew "them," probably the houses. The text of verses 4–5 is difficult.
- d (33:14) Verses 14–26 are absent from the Septuagint (Brenton). They expand the promise of 23:5–6 and are among the longest passages in the Hebrew text with no Greek counterpart. Item for scholarly review.
- e (33:15) Compare 23:5, where the same promise appears in slightly different words.
- f (33:16) Hebrew Yahweh Tsidqenu. At 23:6 the name is given to the king; here it is given to the city.

- g (33:24) Probably Israel and Judah, though some take it as Judah and the house of David, or the royal and priestly lines of verses 17–22.

Chapter 34

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh when Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, with his whole army, every kingdom of the earth under his rule, and all the peoples, were fighting against Jerusalem and against all its towns: 2 "So says Yahweh, God of Israel: Go and speak to Zedekiah king of Judah; tell him, 'So says Yahweh: Look, I am delivering this city into the grip of Babylon's king, and he will burn it with fire. 3 And you yourself will not slip from his grip; you will surely be seized and handed over to him. Your eyes will look into the eyes of Babylon's king, his mouth will speak to your mouth, and to Babylon you will go. 4 Yet hear Yahweh's word, O Zedekiah king of Judah: So says Yahweh concerning you: You will not die by the sword. 5 In peace you will die. And as spices were burned for your fathers, the former kings who were before you, so they will burn spices for you and lament for you, "Alas, lord!" For I myself have spoken the word, declares Yahweh.'" 6 Then Jeremiah the prophet spoke all these words to Zedekiah king of Judah in Jerusalem, 7 while the army of Babylon's king was fighting against Jerusalem and against all the towns of Judah still holding out, Lachish and Azekah;[a] for these alone among Judah's towns remained as fortified cities.

8 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh after King Zedekiah had made a covenant with all the people in Jerusalem to proclaim release[b] to them: 9 that each should set free his Hebrew slave, male or female, so that no one should hold a fellow Judean in bondage. 10 And all the officials and all the people who had entered into the covenant obeyed: each would set free his male and female slave and no longer hold them in bondage. They obeyed and let them go. 11 Later, though, they reversed course, fetched back the menservants and maidservants they had freed, and subdued them again into servitude.[c]

12 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 13 "So says Yahweh, God of Israel: I myself cut a covenant with your fathers on the day I brought them out of the land of Egypt, out of the house

of slaves, saying, 14 ‘When seven years end[d] you shall each release
your Hebrew kinsman who was sold to you; six years he serves you,
and then you must dismiss him from you a free man.’ Your ancestors,
though, paid me no heed and turned no ear. 15 You yourselves turned
back today and did what was right in my eyes, proclaiming release
each to his neighbor, and you cut a covenant before me in the house
that bears my name. 16 But then you turned and profaned my name:
each took back his male and female slave whom you had sent away
free at their own desire, and you forced them to be your male and
female slaves. 17 Therefore so says Yahweh: You have not obeyed me
by proclaiming release each to his brother and to his neighbor. Look,
I proclaim to you a release, declares Yahweh—to the sword, to plague,
and to famine;[e] and I will make you a horror to all the kingdoms of
the earth. 18 The men who overstepped my covenant, not upholding
the covenant’s words that they cut in my presence, I will render like[f]
the calf they sliced in two, between whose halves they walked— 19
the officials of Judah, the officials of Jerusalem, the court officials, the
priests, and all the people of the land who passed between the parts
of the calf. 20 I will give them into the hand of their enemies and of
those who seek their life; their corpses shall be food for the birds of
the heavens and the beasts of the earth. 21 And Zedekiah king of Judah
and his officials I will give into the hand of their enemies, of those
who seek their life, of the army of Babylon’s king that has withdrawn
from you.[g] 22 Look, I am giving command, declares Yahweh, and I will
bring them back to this city. They will fight against it, take it, and
burn it with fire; and the towns of Judah I will make a desolation
without inhabitant.”

Notes

- a (34:7) Lachish and Azekah were fortress towns in the Judean lowland southwest of Jerusalem. Ostraca found at Lachish (the “Lachish letters”) are reported to mention watching for the signals of Azekah, probably from this period.
- b (34:8) Hebrew deror, “release, liberty,” the term used for the Jubilee in Leviticus 25:10.
- c (34:11) The Septuagint shortens verses 10–11 (Brenton 41:10–11).
- d (34:14) So the Hebrew, counting inclusively (compare Deuteronomy 15:1, 12). The Septuagint reads “When six years are accomplished” (Brenton).

- e (34:17) The Hebrew plays on deror, “release”: those who would not release their slaves are released to disaster.
- f (34:18) Hebrew lacks “like”; the comparison is implied. The rite of passing between the halves of an animal (compare Genesis 15:9–17) called down its fate on any party who broke the covenant.
- g (34:21) The Babylonian army had temporarily lifted the siege when an Egyptian force approached (37:5).

Chapter 35

1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh in the days of
Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah: 2 “Go to the house of the
Rechabites,[a] speak with them, and bring them into Yahweh’s house,
into one of the chambers, and give them wine to drink.” 3 So I brought
Jaazaniah[b] son of Jeremiah, the son of Habazziniah, together with his
brothers, all his sons and the entire Rechabite family, 4 and I brought
them into Yahweh’s house, into the chamber of the sons of Hanan
son of Igdaliah, the man of God, which was beside the officials’
chamber, above the chamber of Maaseiah son of Shallum, keeper of
the threshold. 5 Then I set before the men of the Rechabite house
bowls brimming with wine, and cups, and said to them, “Drink wine.”
6 But they answered, “We drink no wine, for Jonadab[c] son of Rechab,
our father, commanded us: ‘You shall drink no wine, neither you nor
your sons, for all time. 7 No house shall you build, no seed shall you
sow, no vineyard shall you plant or own; but in tents you shall dwell
all your days, so that you may live many days on the face of the land
where you sojourn.’ 8 We have obeyed the voice of Jonadab son of
Rechab, our father, in all he charged us: to drink no wine all our days,
we, our wives, our sons, and our daughters, 9 and to build no houses
to dwell in. Vineyard, field, and seed we have none. 10 We have lived
in tents and have obeyed everything our ancestor Jonadab ordered us
to do. 11 But when Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon came up against
the land, we said, ‘Come, let us go into Jerusalem before the army of
the Chaldeans and the army of Aram.’ So we are living in Jerusalem.”
12 Then Yahweh’s word came to Jeremiah: 13 “So says Yahweh of
Armies, God of Israel: Go and say to the men of Judah and the
inhabitants of Jerusalem, Will you not take correction and listen to

my words? declares Yahweh. 14 The words of Jonadab son of Rechab, which he commanded his sons, not to drink wine, have been kept; to this day they drink none, for they obey their father's command. But I have spoken to you early and persistently, and you have not listened to me. 15 Every one of my servants the prophets I dispatched to you, rising early to send them, with the message: 'Come back, each of you, from your wicked course; make your conduct good; stop chasing other gods to worship them; then you will remain on the soil I granted you and your ancestors.' Yet you lent no ear and heeded me not. 16 The sons of Jonadab son of Rechab have kept the command their father gave them, but this people has not listened to me. 17 Therefore so says Yahweh, God of Armies, God of Israel: Look, I am bringing on Judah and on all the inhabitants of Jerusalem all the calamity I have pronounced against them, because I spoke to them and they did not listen, I called to them and they did not answer."
18 Then Jeremiah told the Rechabite family, "This is what Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: You have obeyed your ancestor Jonadab's order, followed all his instructions and done everything he told you, 19 so this is what Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: Jonadab son of Rechab will always have a descendant to serve me."[d]

Notes

- a (35:2) The Rechabites were a clan descended from Jonadab son of Rechab (verse 6), who kept a semi-nomadic life of abstinence; they are linked with the Kenites in 1 Chronicles 2:55. Rechab may mean "rider" or "charioteer." The Septuagint calls them "the Archabin" (Brenton).
- b (35:3) Jaazaniah, "Yahweh listens." The Septuagint calls him "Jechonias the son of Jeremin" (Brenton).
- c (35:6) Jonadab (also Jehonadab), "Yahweh is generous." He took part in Jehu's purge of Baal worship (2 Kings 10:15–23), about 840 B.C., some two and a half centuries before this episode.
- d (35:19) To "stand before" Yahweh is the language of service. The Septuagint adds "before my face while the earth remains" (Brenton).

Chapter 36

1 In the fourth year of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah,[a] this word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh: 2 "Take for yourself a scroll[b] and write on it every word I have spoken to you against Israel and

against Judah and against all the nations, from the day I first spoke to you, in the days of Josiah, until this day. 3 Perhaps the house of Judah will hear of all the calamity I intend to do to them, so that each will turn from his evil way, and I may forgive their guilt and their sin."
4 Jeremiah therefore summoned Baruch son of Neriah, and from Jeremiah's lips[c] Baruch inscribed on a scroll every word that Yahweh had spoken to him. 5 Then Jeremiah charged Baruch: "I am restricted;[d] I cannot enter Yahweh's house. 6 So you go, and on a day of fasting read aloud from the scroll that you wrote as I dictated, so that the people in Yahweh's house hear Yahweh's words; also read them to all the people of Judah who come in from their towns. 7 Perhaps their plea will fall before Yahweh, and each will turn from his evil way; for great is the anger and the wrath that Yahweh has pronounced against this people." 8 And Baruch son of Neriah did all that Jeremiah the prophet commanded him, reading from the book the words of Yahweh in Yahweh's house.
9 In the fifth year[e] of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah, in the ninth month (November–December),[f] the whole population of Jerusalem and everyone who had come from Judah's towns to Jerusalem announced a fast before Yahweh. 10 Then Baruch read out Jeremiah's words from the scroll, with all the people listening, in Yahweh's house. He stood in the room of Gemariah son of Shaphan the scribe, up in the higher courtyard by the New Gate entrance of Yahweh's house.
11 Micaiah son of Gemariah son of Shaphan, on hearing out of the book every one of Yahweh's words, 12 he went down into the royal palace, to the secretary's chamber. The officials were all seated there: Elishama the secretary, Delaiah son of Shemaiah, Elnathan son of Achbor, Gemariah son of Shaphan, Zedekiah son of Hananiah, and the rest of the officials. 13 And Micaiah told them all the words he had heard when Baruch read the book in the hearing of the people. 14 Then all the officials sent Jehudi son of Nethaniah son of Shelemiah son of Cushi to Baruch, saying, "The scroll that you read in the hearing of the people—take it in your hand and come." So Baruch son of Neriah took the scroll in his hand and came to them. 15 They said to him, "Sit

down and read it in our hearing." So Baruch read it in their hearing. 16
When they heard all the words, they turned in alarm to one another
and said to Baruch, "We must certainly report all these words to the
king." 17 Baruch they then questioned: "Explain to us—these words,
how did you come to write them all? Was it from his lips?" 18 Baruch
answered them, "From his own mouth he recited all these words to
me, while I wrote them in ink on the scroll." 19 Then the officials told
Baruch, "Go and hide, you and Jeremiah, and don't let anyone know
where you are."
20 So they went in to the king in the court, having deposited the scroll
in the chamber of Elishama the scribe, and reported all the words in
the king's hearing. 21 Then the king sent Jehudi to get the scroll, and
he took it from the chamber of Elishama the scribe. Jehudi read it
in the hearing of the king and of all the officials standing beside the
king. 22 The king was sitting in the winter house in the ninth month
(in November–December),[g] with a fire burning in the brazier before
him. 23 Each time Jehudi had read out three or four columns,[h] the king
sliced them away with a penknife and tossed them onto the brazier's
flames, till the scroll was burned up whole on the brazier fire. 24
Neither king nor courtier, though hearing all these words, felt any
dread; no one ripped his clothes. 25 Elnathan, Delaiah and Gemariah
even begged the king not to burn the scroll, but he refused to listen to
them.[i] 26 The king ordered Jerahmeel, a prince, along with Seraiah son
of Azriel and Shelemiah son of Abdeel, to arrest Baruch the scribe
and the prophet Jeremiah. But Yahweh concealed them.
27 Now after the king had burned the scroll with the words Baruch
wrote at Jeremiah's dictation, Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah: 28
"Take a new scroll and copy onto it all the earlier words that stood
on the first scroll, the one Jehoiakim king of Judah burned. 29 And
concerning Jehoiakim king of Judah you shall say, 'So says Yahweh:
You have burned this scroll, saying, "Why have you written on it that
the king of Babylon will certainly come and destroy this land and cut
off from it man and beast?" 30 Therefore so says Yahweh concerning
Jehoiakim king of Judah: He shall have no one to sit on the throne of
David, and his dead body shall be cast out to the heat by day and the

frost by night. 31 I will punish him and his offspring and his servants for their guilt; I will bring on them, on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and on the men of Judah all the calamity I pronounced against them, but they would not listen.'" 32 Then Jeremiah took another scroll and gave it to Baruch son of Neriah the scribe, who wrote on it at Jeremiah's dictation all the words of the book that Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire. And many similar words were added to them.

Notes

- a (36:1) That is, 605–604 B.C., the year of the battle of Carchemish (46:2).
- b (36:2) Hebrew "a scroll of a book," a roll of papyrus or leather.
- c (36:4) Hebrew "from the mouth of Jeremiah"; so also "at my (his) dictation" in verses 6, 17, 27, 32.
- d (36:5) Hebrew ʿatsur, "restrained, hindered"; the reason is not stated. The Septuagint reads "I am in prison" (Brenton), though 36:19, 26 suggest he was not under arrest.
- e (36:9) That is, 604–603 B.C. The Septuagint reads "in the eighth year" (Brenton).
- f (36:9) Hebrew "the ninth month," Kislev. A fast may have been called because of the Babylonian advance; 604 B.C. saw Nebuchadnezzar's campaign against Ashkelon.
- g (36:22) Hebrew "the ninth month," Kislev, the cold, rainy season.
- h (36:23) Hebrew delathoth, "doors," that is, columns of writing on the scroll.
- i (36:25) The Septuagint reverses the sense: "But Elnathan and Godolias suggested to the king that he should burn the roll" (Brenton).

Chapter 37

1 Zedekiah son of Josiah reigned as king in place of Coniah son of Jehoiakim, having been made king over the land of Judah by Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon. 2 But neither he nor his servants nor the people of the land listened to the words of Yahweh that he spoke through Jeremiah the prophet.

3 King Zedekiah sent Jehucal[a] son of Shelemiah and the priest Zephaniah son of Maaseiah to the prophet Jeremiah to say, "Please pray to Yahweh our God for us." 4 Jeremiah at that point still moved freely in and out among the populace; nobody had yet locked him up. 5 In the meantime Pharaoh's army had marched out of Egypt, and when

the Chaldeans who were besieging Jerusalem heard the news about them, they pulled back from Jerusalem.[b]
6 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah the prophet: 7 "This is what
Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: To the king of Judah, who sent you
to consult me, say this: Look, Pharaoh's army, which set out to help
you, is going home to Egypt. 8 And the Chaldeans will come back
and fight against this city; they will capture it and burn it with fire.
9 So says Yahweh: Do not fool your own souls by telling yourselves,
'Off from us the Chaldeans are sure to march.' Depart they will not.
10 Even if you were to strike down the whole army of the Chaldeans
fighting against you, and there remained among them only wounded
men, each in his tent, they would rise up and burn this city with fire."
11 Now when, on account of Pharaoh's forces, the Chaldean host had
pulled back from Jerusalem, 12 Jeremiah set out from Jerusalem to go to
the land of Benjamin to take his share[c] there among the people. 13 But
at the Benjamin Gate the sentry in command, whose name was Irijah
son of Shelemiah, the son of Hananiah, grabbed the prophet Jeremiah
and said, "You are going over to the Chaldeans!" 14 "False!" Jeremiah
replied. "To the Chaldeans I am not defecting." Irijah, though, refused
to hear him; he laid hold of Jeremiah and led him off to the officials. 15
The officials were enraged at Jeremiah; they beat him and put him in
confinement in the house of Jonathan the scribe, for they had made
it into a prison. 16 So Jeremiah went into the cistern house,[d] into the
vaulted cells, and remained there many days.
17 Then King Zedekiah sent and had him brought, and the king ques-
tioned him secretly in his house: "Is there any word from Yahweh?"
Jeremiah said, "There is." And he said, "Into the hand of Babylon's
king you will be given." 18 Jeremiah further asked King Zedekiah, "In
what have I sinned against you, your courtiers, or this people, that
you have locked me up in a jail? 19 Where are your prophets now, the
ones who told you, 'The king of Babylon will not attack you or this
land'? 20 So now, my lord king, kindly hear me: may my petition come
before your face. Do not return me to Jonathan the secretary's house,
or there I shall perish." 21 King Zedekiah then gave the order. Jeremiah
was entrusted to the guard's courtyard, and each day a round loaf

from the Street of the Bakers was handed him, till the city's bread ran out entirely. Thus Jeremiah stayed on in the guard's courtyard.

Notes

- a (37:3) Jehucal, "Yahweh is able." He is called Jucal at 38:1. A clay seal impression reading "Yehukal son of Shelemyahu" has been reported from excavations in Jerusalem. Item for scholarly review.
- b (37:5) This lifting of the siege is the setting of 34:21–22 as well.
- c (37:12) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; perhaps to receive a share of a family inheritance (compare 32:6–15). The Septuagint reads "to buy thence a property in the midst of the people" (Brenton).
- d (37:16) Hebrew "the house of the cistern," an underground dungeon.

Chapter 38

1 Word of what Jeremiah was proclaiming to the whole populace
reached the ears of Shephatiah, Mattan's son; of Gedaliah, Pashhur's
son; of Jucal, Shelemiah's son; and of Pashhur, Malchiah's son: 2 "So
says Yahweh: Whoever remains in this city will die by sword, by
famine, and by plague; but whoever goes out to the Chaldeans will
live; he will have his life as a prize of war[a] and live. 3 So says Yahweh:
This city will surely be given into the hand of the army of Babylon's
king, and he will capture it." 4 The officials then told the king, "This
fellow must be executed. He is slackening the hands of the fighting
men still left in the city, and of all the people too, with words like
these. This fellow seeks not the good of this people but its ruin." 5
"There—he is in your power," King Zedekiah replied, "for against you
the king is helpless." 6 Jeremiah they took and flung into Malchiah the
king's son's cistern within the guard's courtyard, lowering him on
cords. Water there was none in the pit, only sludge, and down into
the sludge Jeremiah sank.
7 Ebed-melech,[b] a Cushite and an official in the royal household, heard
that they had lowered Jeremiah into the cistern. At that time the king
was seated in the Benjamin Gate. 8 Ebed-melech left the palace and
said to the king: 9 "My lord the king, these men have done evil in all
they have done to Jeremiah the prophet, casting him into the cistern;
he will die of hunger where he is, for there is no more bread in the
city." 10 Then the king commanded Ebed-melech the Cushite, "Take

thirty men[c] with you from here and draw Jeremiah the prophet up out of the cistern before he dies." 11 So Ebed-melech took the men with him and went into the king's house, to a place beneath the storehouse, and took from there worn-out rags and old clothes, and let them down by ropes to Jeremiah in the cistern. 12 Ebed-melech the Cushite said to Jeremiah, "Put the worn-out rags and clothes under your armpits, beneath the ropes." Jeremiah did so. 13 Then they pulled Jeremiah up with the ropes and drew him out of the cistern. And Jeremiah remained in the court of the guard.

14 King Zedekiah summoned Jeremiah the prophet, bringing him to himself at the third entryway of Yahweh's house. "A question I shall put to you," the king told Jeremiah. "Keep nothing back from me."

15 Jeremiah answered Zedekiah, "If I answer you, you will certainly have me killed. And if I advise you, you will not listen to me."

16 Then King Zedekiah swore secretly to Jeremiah, "As Yahweh lives, who made this life for us, I will not put you to death or give you into the hand of these men who seek your life."

17 Then Jeremiah said to Zedekiah, "So says Yahweh, God of Armies, God of Israel: If you will indeed go out to the officers of Babylon's king, your life will be spared, and this city will not be burned with fire; you and your household will live.

18 But if you do not surrender to the officers of the king of Babylon, then this city will be handed over to the Chaldeans, who will set it on fire, and you will not escape from them."

19 "It is the Judeans gone over to the Chaldeans that I dread," King Zedekiah told Jeremiah, "that I may be surrendered into their hands and they make sport of me."

20 Jeremiah said, "You will not be handed over. Obey, I beg you, the voice of Yahweh in what I am telling you, and it will go well with you, and your life will be spared.

21 But if you refuse to go out, this is what Yahweh has shown me:

22 Look, all the women left in the house of Judah's king will be led out to the officers of Babylon's king, and they will say,

'They misled you and overcame you,
those trusted friends of yours;[d]

now that your feet are sunk in the mire,
they have turned away from you.'
23 Every wife and son of yours will be marched out to the Chaldeans.
Neither shall you escape their grip; in the grip of Babylon's king you
will be caught, and this city will be burned[e] to the ground."
24 Then Zedekiah said to Jeremiah, "Let no one know of these words,
and you will not die. 25 If the officials hear that I have talked with you,
and they approach you and ask, 'Tell us what you said to the king and
what he said to you; keep nothing back from us and we will not kill
you,' 26 then you shall say to them, 'I was presenting my plea before
the king, that he would not send me back to the house of Jonathan
to die there.'" 27 Sure enough, the officials all came to Jeremiah and
interrogated him, and he gave them answer exactly in the terms the
king had ordered. Then they left off questioning him, since nobody
had overheard the matter. 28 And Jeremiah remained in the court of
the guard until the day Jerusalem was captured.[f]

Notes

- a (38:2) Hebrew "his life shall be to him as spoil," that is, he will escape with his life and nothing more.
- b (38:7) Ebed-melech, "servant of the king." A Cushite, that is, from the upper Nile region (Nubia). He is promised deliverance in 39:15–18.
- c (38:10) So the Hebrew, followed by the Septuagint (Brenton). One Hebrew manuscript is reported to read "three men," which some prefer as more likely for the task.
- d (38:22) Hebrew "the men of your peace." The lines echo Obadiah 7.
- e (38:23) So the ancient versions; the Hebrew reads "and you will burn this city," that is, you will be the cause of its burning.
- f (38:28) The last clause of the Hebrew, "and it came to pass when Jerusalem was taken," introduces 39:1 in many translations.

Chapter 39

1 In the ninth year of Zedekiah king of Judah, in the tenth month (in
December–January),[a] Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon and his whole
army came against Jerusalem and laid siege to it. 2 In Zedekiah's
eleventh year, in the fourth month (in June–July),[b] on the ninth day
of the month, the city wall was breached. 3 Then all the officials of
Babylon's king came in and took their seats in the Middle Gate: Ner-

gal-sharezer, Samgar-nebo, Sarsechim the Rab-saris, Nergal-sharezer
the Rab-mag,[c] and all the rest of the officials of Babylon's king.
4 On seeing them,[d] Zedekiah king of Judah and every fighting man
took flight; under cover of night they slipped out of the city along the
royal garden path, by the gateway between the double walls, and he
headed off in the direction of the Arabah. 5 But the Chaldean army
pursued them and overtook Zedekiah in the plains of Jericho. They
seized him and brought him up to Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon
at Riblah in the land of Hamath, and he passed sentence on him. 6
The king of Babylon slaughtered Zedekiah's sons at Riblah before his
eyes; all the nobles of Judah, too, the king of Babylon slaughtered. 7
Zedekiah's eyes he put out, and bound him in bronze fetters to take
him to Babylon. 8 The Chaldeans burned the king's house and the
houses of the people with fire, and tore down the walls of Jerusalem.
9 Then Nebuzaradan[e] the captain of the guard took the people who
were still in the city, those who had defected to him and the rest of
the population, into exile in Babylon. 10 Some of the destitute, though,
who possessed nothing at all, Nebuzaradan the guard commander
let remain in Judah's land, and handed over to them vineyards and
plowland that day.
11 Regarding Jeremiah, Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon issued orders
by way of Nebuzaradan the guard commander: 12 "Fetch him; keep
your eyes on his welfare; harm him in nothing. Rather, whatever he
asks of you, so treat him." 13 So Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard,
Nebushazban the Rab-saris, Nergal-sharezer the Rab-mag, and all the
chief officers of Babylon's king sent 14 and took Jeremiah from the
court of the guard and entrusted him to Gedaliah[f] son of Ahikam son
of Shaphan, to bring him home. So he stayed among the people.
15 Yahweh's word had come to Jeremiah while he was shut up in the
court of the guard: 16 "Go and say to Ebed-melech the Cushite, 'So says
Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: Look, I am bringing my words upon
this city for calamity and not for good, and they will come to pass
before you on that day. 17 But I will rescue you on that day, declares
Yahweh; you will not be handed over to the men you fear. 18 For rescue

you I most certainly will; by the sword you shall not fall. Your life shall be your booty, since in me you put your trust, declares Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (39:1) Hebrew "the tenth month," Tevet; that is, January 588 B.C. (compare 52:4; 2 Kings 25:1). The Septuagint reads only "in the ninth month of Zedekiah" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (39:2) Hebrew "the fourth month," Tammuz; that is, July 587 or 586 B.C. The exact year is debated. Item for scholarly review.
- c (39:3) Rab-saris and Rab-mag are Babylonian titles, perhaps "chief official" and "chief magus" or "high officer." The division of the names is uncertain; Samgar-nebo and Sarsechim may be a single name or a title and a name. Nergal-sharezer may be Neriglissar, a later king of Babylon (560–556 B.C.). Item for scholarly review.
- d (39:4) Verses 4–13 are absent from the Septuagint (Brenton). Verses 4–10 closely parallel 52:7–16 and 2 Kings 25:4–12.
- e (39:9) Nebuzaradan, Akkadian Nabu-zer-iddin, "Nabu has given offspring." His title, rab-ṭabbaḥim, is literally "chief of the butchers" or "chief cook," a high military office.
- f (39:14) Gedaliah, "Yahweh is great." Son of Ahikam, who had protected Jeremiah (26:24). He was appointed governor of Judah after the fall of Jerusalem (40:5).

Chapter 40

1 This is the message that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh after Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard let him go at Ramah. Nebuzaradan had found him bound in chains among the prisoners of Jerusalem and Judah who were being deported to Babylon.[a] 2 The captain of the guard took Jeremiah and said to him, "Yahweh your God pronounced this calamity against this place. 3 Yahweh has brought it about and done as he said, because you sinned against Yahweh and did not obey his voice. So this thing has happened to you. 4 So now, look: today I am loosing the fetters from your wrists. Should coming along with me to Babylon please you, come, and I will keep an eye on you; should it displease you, stay. Look—all the land lies open before you; wherever you judge it good and fitting to go, go there." 5 When Jeremiah still had not turned back,[b] he said, "Go back, then, to Gedaliah son of Ahikam son of Shaphan, whom the king of Babylon has appointed over the towns of Judah, and stay with him among the people, or go wherever it seems right to you to go." So the captain of the guard gave him

provisions and a present, and let him go. 6 Jeremiah went off, then, to Mizpah[c] to Gedaliah son of Ahikam and lived with him in the midst of those still left in the land.

7 The army officers and their troops who were still out in the open country heard that the king of Babylon had appointed Gedaliah son of Ahikam as governor of the land and had placed under his care the men, women and children, the poorest of the land, who had not been deported to Babylon. 8 to Mizpah they came to Gedaliah—Ishmael[d] son of Nethaniah; Kareah's sons Johanan[e] and Jonathan; Seraiah son of Tanhumeth; the sons of Ephai from Netophah; and Jezaniah, son of a Maacathite—each with his men. 9 Gedaliah son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, gave them and their men his oath: "Do not be afraid to serve the Chaldeans. Stay in the land, serve the king of Babylon, and everything will be fine for you. 10 As for me, look, I will stay at Mizpah to stand before the Chaldeans who come to us; but you, gather wine, summer fruit, and oil, store them in your vessels, and settle in your towns that you have taken over." 11 Likewise, when all the Judeans in Moab, among the Ammonites, in Edom, and in all the other lands heard that the king of Babylon had left a remnant in Judah and had appointed over them Gedaliah son of Ahikam son of Shaphan, 12 they all came back from every place where they had been scattered and arrived in the land of Judah, at Mizpah, to Gedaliah; and they harvested a huge amount of wine and summer fruit.

13 Johanan son of Kareah next came to Mizpah to Gedaliah, along with every captain of the troops out in the countryside, 14 and said to him, "Do you know that Baalis[f] king of the Ammonites has sent Ishmael son of Nethaniah to take your life?" But Gedaliah son of Ahikam would not believe them. 15 Then Johanan son of Kareah spoke secretly to Gedaliah at Mizpah: "Let me go and strike down Ishmael son of Nethaniah, and no one will know. Why should he take your life, so that all the Judeans gathered around you are scattered and the remnant of Judah perishes?" 16 But Gedaliah son of Ahikam said to Johanan son of Kareah, "You shall not do this thing, for you are speaking a lie about Ishmael."

Notes

- a (40:1) The introduction “The word that came to Jeremiah” is not followed by a prophetic oracle until 42:7; the chapters that follow narrate events after the fall of Jerusalem. Ramah lay about 5 miles (8 km) north of Jerusalem and was apparently a staging point for deportation.
- b (40:5) The Hebrew is difficult; perhaps “before he could answer.”
- c (40:6) Mizpah, “watchtower,” a town in Benjamin, often identified with Tell en-Nasbeh, north of Jerusalem.
- d (40:8) Ishmael, “God hears.” He was of royal descent (41:1).
- e (40:8) Johanan, “Yahweh has been gracious.”
- f (40:14) Baalis, perhaps “son of delight.” A seal impression reported to name “Baʿalyishaʿ king of the Ammonites” may refer to him. Item for scholarly review.

Chapter 41

1 It was the seventh month (in September–October)[a] when Ishmael
son of Nethaniah son of Elishama—of the royal line, and among the
king’s high officers—arrived with ten men at Mizpah to Gedaliah son
of Ahikam. While they shared bread together there in Mizpah, 2 up
sprang Ishmael son of Nethaniah, and the ten men accompanying
him, and cut down Gedaliah son of Ahikam son of Shaphan by the
sword; thus he killed the one Babylon’s king had put in charge of the
land. 3 Every Judean with Gedaliah in Mizpah Ishmael likewise cut
down, and the Chaldean fighting men found on the spot.
4 On the day after Gedaliah’s murder, before anyone knew of it, 5
eighty men arrived from Shechem, Shiloh,[b] and Samaria, their beards
shaved, their clothes torn, their bodies gashed, carrying grain offer-
ings and incense to bring to Yahweh’s house.[c] 6 Out from Mizpah
to intercept them went Ishmael son of Nethaniah, sobbing all the
way. Upon reaching them he urged, “Come along to Gedaliah son
of Ahikam.” 7 Once they were inside the town, though, Ishmael son
of Nethaniah butchered them, he and his companions, and pitched
them into a cistern. 8 But ten men among them said to Ishmael, “Do
not kill us, for we have stores hidden in the field—wheat, barley,
oil, and honey.” So he held back and did not kill them along with
their companions. 9 Now the cistern into which Ishmael threw all the
corpses of the men he had struck down because of Gedaliah[d] was
the one King Asa had made against Baasha king of Israel. Ishmael
son of Nethaniah filled it with the slain. 10 Then Ishmael led away

into captivity all who were left in Mizpah: the princesses of the royal house and the townsfolk remaining there, those Nebuzaradan the guard commander had entrusted to Gedaliah son of Ahikam. With these prisoners Ishmael son of Nethaniah set off, aiming to pass over to Ammon's territory.

11 But when Johanan son of Kareah and all the commanders of the forces with him heard of all the evil Ishmael son of Nethaniah had done, 12 they took all their men and went to fight Ishmael son of Nethaniah, and they found him at the great pool in Gibeon. 13 When all the people with Ishmael saw Johanan son of Kareah and all the commanders of the forces with him, they rejoiced. 14 All the captives Ishmael had taken from Mizpah turned around, came back and joined Johanan son of Kareah. 15 But Ishmael son of Nethaniah escaped from Johanan with eight men and went to the Ammonites. 16 Johanan son of Kareah and all the army officers with him took all the survivors from Mizpah whom he had rescued from Ishmael son of Nethaniah, after Ishmael had killed Gedaliah son of Ahikam—soldiers, women, children and court officials, whom Johanan had brought back from Gibeon. 17 Off they went and halted at Geruth Chimham[e] close by Bethlehem, meaning to proceed into Egypt 18 to escape the Chaldeans, whom they feared because Ishmael son of Nethaniah had murdered Gedaliah son of Ahikam, whom the king of Babylon had appointed governor of the land.

Notes

- a (41:1) Hebrew "the seventh month," Tishri; the year is not stated (perhaps 587 or 586 B.C., or later). Jewish tradition later observed a fast in the seventh month in memory of Gedaliah (compare Zechariah 7:5; 8:19).
- b (41:5) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "Salem" (Brenton).
- c (41:5) The marks of mourning suggest pilgrims grieving over the destroyed temple, bringing offerings to its site.
- d (41:9) Hebrew "by the hand of Gedaliah," perhaps "alongside Gedaliah." The Septuagint reads "is the great pit" (Brenton), which may reflect a different reading of similar Hebrew letters.
- e (41:17) Or "the lodging place of Chimham"; compare 2 Samuel 19:37–40. The Septuagint reads "Gaberoch-amaa" (Brenton).

Chapter 42

1 Then all the commanders of the forces, with Johanan son of Kareah
and Jezaniah[a] son of Hoshaiah, and all the people from the least to
the greatest, came near 2 and said to Jeremiah the prophet, "Let our
plea fall before you, and pray for us to Yahweh your God, for all this
remnant—for we are left as a few out of many, as your own eyes see
us— 3 so that Yahweh your God may show us which road to walk
and what course to take." 4 Jeremiah the prophet said to them, "I have
heard you. Look, I will pray to Yahweh your God as you ask, and
whatever Yahweh answers you I will tell you; I will hold back nothing
from you." 5 And they said to Jeremiah, "May Yahweh be a true and
faithful witness against us if we do not act according to every word
that Yahweh your God sends you to tell us. 6 Whether it is good or bad,
the voice of Yahweh our God, to whom we send you, we will obey,
so that it may go well with us when we obey the voice of Yahweh
our God."
7 At the end of ten days Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah. 8 He called
Johanan son of Kareah and all the commanders of the forces with him,
and all the people from the least to the greatest, 9 and said to them,
"So says Yahweh, God of Israel, to whom you sent me to present your
plea before him: 10 If you will indeed remain in this land, then I will
build you up and not pull you down; I will plant you and not uproot
you; for I relent of the calamity I have done to you.[b] 11 Do not fear
the king of Babylon, whom you now fear; do not fear him, declares
Yahweh, for I am with you to save you and to rescue you from his
hand. 12 I will grant you mercy, so that he will have mercy on you and
let you return to your own soil. 13 But should you declare, 'In this land
we refuse to remain,' and so turn a deaf ear to Yahweh your God's
voice, 14 insisting, 'Not so! Egypt's land is where we shall go, where
no warfare will meet our eyes, no ram's horn our ears, no craving
for food our bellies; there we will settle,' 15 then hear now Yahweh's
word, O remnant of Judah: So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel:
If you are firmly set on going to Egypt and go to sojourn there, 16 the
sword you fear will overtake you there in the land of Egypt, and the
famine you dread will cling to you there in Egypt, and there you will

die. 17 Everyone who is determined to go to Egypt and live there will
die by sword, famine or plague; none will survive or get away from
the disaster I will bring on them. 18 This is what Yahweh of Armies,
the God of Israel, says: Just as my anger and fury poured out on the
people living in Jerusalem, so my fury will pour out on you when
you enter Egypt. You will become a curse, an object of horror, a
cursing word and a disgrace, and you will never see this place again.
19 Yahweh has spoken to you, O remnant of Judah: Do not go to Egypt.
Know for certain that I have warned you today 20 that you have erred
to your own peril.[c] You yourselves dispatched me to Yahweh your
God with the words, 'Intercede for us with Yahweh our God; all that
Yahweh our God declares, report to us, and we will carry it out.' 21 I
have declared it to you today, but you have not obeyed the voice of
Yahweh your God in anything he sent me to tell you. 22 So understand
clearly that you will die by sword, famine or plague in the place you
want to go to live."

Notes

- a (42:1) The Septuagint reads "Azarias the son of Maasæas" (Brenton); compare 43:2, where the Hebrew has Azariah son of Hoshaiah.
- b (42:10) Or "for I grieve over the calamity." Hebrew niḥamti expresses a change of heart; it is often rendered "repent" or "regret."
- c (42:20) Or "you have deceived yourselves"; the Hebrew is uncertain.

Chapter 43

1 When Jeremiah had finished telling all the people everything
Yahweh their God had sent him to say, 2 Azariah son of Hoshaiah
and Johanan son of Kareah, with every arrogant man among them,
retorted to Jeremiah, "Falsehood is what you are telling! Yahweh our
God never sent you with the words, 'Do not enter Egypt to live as
aliens there.' 3 No—it is Baruch son of Neriah stirring you up against
us, so as to put us in Chaldean hands, to be killed or deported to
Babylon." 4 So Johanan son of Kareah, all the commanders of the
forces, and all the people did not obey the voice of Yahweh to stay in
the land of Judah. 5 Rather, Johanan son of Kareah, along with every
troop captain, gathered up all Judah's remnant—those who had come
home from every nation where they had been scattered to dwell in

Judah's land— 6 the men, women and children, the king's daughters,
and everyone Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard had left with
Gedaliah son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, and also the prophet
Jeremiah and Baruch son of Neriah. 7 and they came into the land of
Egypt, for they did not obey the voice of Yahweh. And they came as
far as Tahpanhes.[a]
8 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah in Tahpanhes: 9 "Take in
your hand some large stones and hide them in the mortar[b] in the
brick terrace at the entrance to Pharaoh's house in Tahpanhes, in the
sight of the men of Judah, 10 and say to them, 'So says Yahweh of
Armies, God of Israel: Look, I am sending for Nebuchadrezzar king of
Babylon, my servant,[c] and I will set his throne above these stones that
I have hidden, and he will spread his royal canopy over them. 11 He will
come and attack Egypt: death for those marked for death, captivity
for those marked for captivity, and the sword for those marked for
the sword. 12 I[d] will set fire to the temples of the gods of Egypt, and
he will burn their idols and carry off their gods. As a shepherd picks
the lice from his cloak, so he will pick Egypt clean, and he will depart
from there unharmed. 13 He will shatter the obelisks[e] of Beth-shemesh
in the land of Egypt, and the temples of Egypt's gods he will burn
with fire.'"

Notes

- a (43:7) Tahpanhes, a fortress city in the eastern Nile Delta, commonly identified with Tell Defenneh (Greek Daphnae).
- b (43:9) Hebrew malet, found only here; the meaning is uncertain ("mortar," "clay," or "pavement"). The Septuagint reads only "hide them in the entrance, at the gate of the house of Pharaoh" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (43:10) The Septuagint lacks "my servant" (Brenton).
- d (43:12) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and other ancient versions read "He will kindle" (Brenton: "he shall kindle").
- e (43:13) Hebrew matstsevoth, "standing stones, pillars." Beth-shemesh, "house of the sun," is Heliopolis (Egyptian On), the city of the sun god; the Septuagint reads "the pillars of Heliopolis that are in On" (Brenton).

Chapter 44

1 The message that came to Jeremiah about all the Jews living in
Egypt, in Migdol, Tahpanhes, Memphis[a] and the region of Pathros:[b] 2

“So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: You yourselves have seen
all the calamity I brought on Jerusalem and on every town of Judah.
Look, today they lie in ruins, with no one living in them, 3 because
of the wickedness they committed to provoke me, going off to burn
incense and serve other gods whom they had not known—neither
they, nor you, nor your fathers. 4 Yet I sent to you all my servants
the prophets, rising early and sending, to say, ‘Oh, do not do this
detestable thing that I hate!’ 5 But they did not listen or turn their
ear, to turn from their wickedness and stop burning incense to other
gods. 6 So my wrath and my anger poured forth and blazed in the
towns of Judah and the streets of Jerusalem, and they became a ruin
and a desolation, as they are this day.
7 “And now so says Yahweh, God of Armies, God of Israel: Why are
you doing great harm to your own souls, cutting off from yourselves
man and woman, child and infant, from the midst of Judah, so as
to leave yourselves no remnant? 8 Why do you provoke me by your
handiwork, offering incense to other gods in Egypt, the place you
moved to, so that you will be destroyed and become a curse and a
disgrace among all earth’s nations? 9 Have you forgotten the crimes of
your ancestors, of the Judean kings and queens,[c] and your own crimes
and those of your wives, committed in Judah and in Jerusalem’s
streets? 10 To this day they have not humbled themselves or shown
reverence or lived by my law and decrees that I gave to you and your
ancestors.
11 “Therefore so says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel: Look, I am
setting my face against you for calamity, to cut off all Judah. 12 I will
take the remnant of Judah who set their faces to go to the land of
Egypt to sojourn there, and in the land of Egypt they will all come
to an end: by sword they will fall, by famine they will be consumed,
from the least to the greatest; by sword and by famine they will die,
and they will become an oath, a horror, a curse, and a reproach. 13 I will
punish those who live in the land of Egypt as I punished Jerusalem,
with sword, famine, and plague, 14 so that of the remnant of Judah
who came to sojourn in the land of Egypt none will escape or survive

to return to the land of Judah, to which they long to return and dwell;
for they will not return, except some fugitives."[d]
15 Every man aware that his wife was offering incense to other gods,
every woman present—a vast gathering—and the whole populace
dwelling in Egypt's land, in Pathros, made reply to Jeremiah: 16 "As for
the word you have spoken to us in Yahweh's name, we will not listen
to you. 17 Rather, we will certainly do everything we have vowed: burn
incense to the Queen of Heaven[e] and pour out drink offerings to her,
as we did, we and our fathers, our kings and our officials, in the towns
of Judah and the streets of Jerusalem. Then we had plenty of food,
and we were well off and saw no calamity. 18 But since we stopped
burning incense to the Queen of Heaven and pouring out drink
offerings to her, we have lacked everything and have been consumed
by sword and by famine." 19 The women added,[f] "And when we were
offering incense to Heaven's Queen and pouring libations to her—
was it apart from our husbands that we baked her cakes stamped with
her likeness[g] and poured libations to her?"
20 To the whole people—men, women, every one of them who had
replied in this way—Jeremiah then spoke: 21 "The incense that you
burned in the towns of Judah and the streets of Jerusalem, you and
your fathers, your kings and your officials, and the people of the land
—did not Yahweh remember it? Did it not come into his mind? 22
Yahweh could no longer tolerate your evil deeds and the detestable
things you did. So your land became a wasteland, a horror and a curse,
empty of people, as you see today. 23 Because you burned incense and
sinned against Yahweh and did not obey the voice of Yahweh or walk
in his law, his statutes, and his testimonies, therefore this calamity
has come upon you, as at this day."
24 Jeremiah said further to all the people and all the women, "Hear
Yahweh's word, all Judah who are in the land of Egypt: 25 This is what
Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: You and your wives have
declared with your mouths and carried out with your hands what
you said: 'We will keep the vows we made, to burn incense to the
Queen of Heaven and pour out drink offerings to her.' Go ahead, then,
keep your vows and fulfill them! 26 But hear Yahweh's word, all you

people of Judah who live in Egypt: Look, I swear by my great name, says Yahweh, that no one from Judah anywhere in Egypt will ever again invoke my name by saying, 'As the Lord Yahweh lives.' 27 Look, I am watching over them for calamity and not for good. All the men of Judah in the land of Egypt will come to an end by sword and by famine until they are wholly gone. 28 Those who escape the sword will come back from Egypt to Judah, only a few, and all the survivors of Judah who went to Egypt to live will find out whose word stands, mine or theirs. 29 And this will be the sign for you, declares Yahweh, that I will punish you in this place, so that you may know that my words will surely stand against you for calamity: 30 So says Yahweh: Look, I am giving Pharaoh Hophra[h] king of Egypt into the hand of his enemies and of those who seek his life, as I gave Zedekiah king of Judah into the hand of Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon, his enemy, who sought his life."

Notes

- a (44:1) Hebrew Noph, Memphis, the old capital of Lower Egypt near modern Cairo.
- b (44:1) Pathros, Upper (southern) Egypt.
- c (44:9) Hebrew "his wives"; the Septuagint reads "of your princes" (Brenton). Item for scholarly review.
- d (44:14) Verses 1–14 are a sermon after the pattern of 7:1–15 and 11:1–17.
- e (44:17) Probably the goddess Ishtar or Astarte (compare 7:18). The Hebrew vowels read melekheth, "work" or "handiwork," perhaps a scribal attempt to avoid the title; many Hebrew manuscripts read malkath, "queen."
- f (44:19) The Hebrew lacks this clause; it is supplied because the speakers are the women ("our husbands"). Some ancient witnesses are reported to include it; Brenton does not.
- g (44:19) Or "to portray her," perhaps cakes in the shape of the goddess or stamped with her image.
- h (44:30) Hophra, Egyptian Wahibre (Greek Apries), Pharaoh 589–570 B.C. He was overthrown in a revolt and later killed. The Septuagint calls him "Uaphres" (Brenton).

Chapter 45

1 This is the message the prophet Jeremiah gave to Baruch son of Neriah, when Baruch wrote these words in a scroll as Jeremiah dictated, in the fourth year of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah:[a]
2 "So says Yahweh, God of Israel, concerning you, Baruch: 3 You said,

‘Woe is me! For Yahweh has added sorrow to my pain; I am worn out with my groaning, and rest I do not find.’ 4 Thus you shall say to him: ‘So says Yahweh: Look, what I have built I am tearing down, and what I have planted I am uprooting—that is, the whole land.[b] 5 And you—great things you are hunting for yourself? Hunt them not. For look, upon all flesh I am bringing disaster, declares Yahweh; but your life I will hand you as booty wherever you may go.’”

Notes

- a (45:1) That is, 605–604 B.C., the year of chapter 36; this short word to Baruch is placed out of chronological order. In the Septuagint it stands at the end of the material corresponding to chapter 44 (Brenton 51:31–35).
- b (45:4) The Septuagint lacks “that is, the whole land” (Brenton 51:34).

Chapter 46

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Jeremiah the prophet concerning the nations.[a]

2 About Egypt. This concerns the army of Pharaoh Neco[b] king of Egypt, which was camped at Carchemish[c] on the Euphrates River, and which Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon defeated in the fourth year of Jehoiakim son of Josiah, king of Judah:

3 “Make ready buckler and shield,
and advance to battle!
4 Harness the horses;
mount, you horsemen!
Take your stations in helmets;
polish the lances;
put on the coats of mail!
5 Why have I seen it?
They are panic-stricken, falling back;
their warriors are beaten down;
they have fled headlong
and do not look back—
terror on every side![d] declares Yahweh.
6 Let not the swift flee,
nor the warrior escape;

in the north, by the river Euphrates,
they have stumbled and fallen.
7 "Who is this, swelling like the Nile,
like streams with heaving waters?
8 Egypt swells like the Nile,
like streams with heaving waters.
'Up I will surge,' he said; 'the earth I will flood;
towns and their townsfolk I will wipe out.'
9 Charge, you horses;
rage, you chariots!
Let the warriors march out:
Cush and Put who handle the shield,
the Ludim who handle and bend the bow.[e]
10 That day belongs to the Lord Yahweh of Armies,
a day of revenge, when he takes vengeance on his enemies.
The sword will eat until it is full
and drink until it is satisfied with their blood;
for the Lord Yahweh of Armies will hold a slaughter
in the northern land by the Euphrates River.
11 Go up to Gilead and get balm,
O virgin daughter of Egypt!
In vain you have multiplied remedies;
there is no new skin for you.
12 The nations have heard of your shame,
and your cry has filled the earth;
for warrior has stumbled against warrior;
together the two of them have fallen."
13 The word that Yahweh spoke to Jeremiah the prophet about the coming of Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon to strike the land of Egypt:
14 "Declare it in Egypt, proclaim it in Migdol;
proclaim it in Memphis and in Tahpanhes;
say, 'Take your stand and get ready,
for the sword devours all around you.'

15 Why has your mighty one been swept away?[f]
He did not stand, because Yahweh thrust him down.
16 Many he caused to totter;
one toppled onto another;
then they said, ‘Up! Back to our kin,
back to the country that bore us,
far from the sword of the oppressor.’
17 There they cried out, ‘Pharaoh king of Egypt is but a noise;
he has let the appointed time go by.’[g]
18 As I live, declares the King,
whose name is Yahweh of Armies,
like Tabor among the mountains,
like Carmel by the sea, one will come.
19 Pack your bags for exile,
you who dwell there, daughter of Egypt!
For Memphis will become a waste,
a ruin without inhabitant.
20 “Egypt is a lovely young cow,
but a horsefly from the north has landed on her—yes, landed!
21 Her mercenaries too, there within her,
are like stall-fattened calves;
they as well wheel around and run, all at once;
they hold no ground;
for their day of disaster is upon them,
their hour of reckoning.
22 Her sound is like a serpent slithering away,[h]
for in force they march,
and with axes they come against her
like woodcutters.
23 They will cut down her forest, declares Yahweh,
impenetrable though it is,
for they are more than locusts;
they are without number.
24 The daughter of Egypt is put to shame;
she is given into the hand of a people from the north.”

25 Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel, says: "Look, I am bringing punishment on Amon of No,[i] and on Pharaoh, and on Egypt with her gods and her kings, on Pharaoh and on those who trust in him. 26 I will deliver them to those seeking their lives, to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and his officers. Later, though, people will live in Egypt as in former times, declares Yahweh.[j]

27 "But you, fear not, O Jacob my servant,
and do not lose heart, O Israel;
for look, I will rescue you from far away,
your offspring from the land of their captivity.
Jacob will come home and be at rest, untroubled,
with none to make him afraid.

28 Do not be afraid, Jacob my servant, declares Yahweh,
for I am with you.
I will completely destroy all the nations
where I have scattered you,
but I will not completely destroy you.
I will discipline you fairly,
but I will certainly not let you go unpunished."[k]

Notes

- a (46:1) Verse 1 heads the oracles against the nations (chapters 46–51). It is absent from the Septuagint (Brenton), which places these oracles after 25:13, in a different order (Elam, Egypt, Babylon, Philistia, Edom, Ammon, Kedar, Damascus, Moab), in Brenton's numbering 25:14 through chapter 31 (see the introduction to Jeremiah).
- b (46:2) Neco II, Pharaoh 610–595 B.C. (compare 2 Kings 23:29–35).
- c (46:2) Carchemish, on the upper Euphrates, where Nebuchadnezzar defeated the Egyptian army in 605 B.C. The Septuagint reads "Charmis" (Brenton).
- d (46:5) Hebrew magor missaviv; compare 6:25; 20:3, 10.
- e (46:9) Cush is the upper Nile region; Put probably Libya; the Ludim perhaps Lydians or an African people.
- f (46:15) The Hebrew word division is uncertain. The Septuagint divides the letters differently and reads "Why has Apis fled from you? Your choice calf has not remained" (Brenton, modernized), a reference to the sacred bull of Memphis. Item for scholarly review.
- g (46:17) Hebrew sha'on he'evir hammo'ed, a pun on Pharaoh's name or title. The Septuagint transliterates: "Saon esbeie moed" (Brenton).
- h (46:22) Hebrew "her voice goes like the serpent," perhaps the hiss of a snake fleeing the woodcutters.

- i (46:25) Amon was the chief god of No (Thebes) in Upper Egypt. The Septuagint reads “Ammon her son” (Brenton).
- j (46:26) Verse 26 is absent from the Septuagint (Brenton).
- k (46:28) Verses 27–28 nearly repeat 30:10–11. Here the Septuagint has them (Brenton 26:27–28).

Chapter 47

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Jeremiah the prophet concerning
the Philistines, before Pharaoh struck Gaza:[a]
2 This is what Yahweh says:
“Look, water is rising in the north,
turning into a flooding river;
it will flood the land and everything in it,
the city and its residents.
People will cry out,
and every resident of the land will wail
3 at the noise of the stamping hoofs of his stallions,
at the rattle of his chariots, the rumble of their wheels.
Fathers do not turn back for their children,
so limp are their hands,
4 because of the day that is coming
to destroy all the Philistines,
to cut off from Tyre and Sidon
every helper who remains.
For Yahweh is destroying the Philistines,
the remnant of the coastland of Caphtor.[b]
5 Shaven bald is Gaza;
Ashkelon struck dumb.
You leftovers of their lowland,[c]
how long will you slash at your flesh?
6 Ah, sword of Yahweh,
how long till you are quiet?
Put yourself back into your sheath;
rest and be still!
7 How can it rest,[d]
when Yahweh has given it orders?

He has assigned it to Ashkelon
and the coast."

Notes

- a (47:1) The occasion is uncertain; perhaps Neco's campaign about 609 B.C. The Septuagint lacks "that came to Jeremiah the prophet" and "before Pharaoh struck Gaza," reading only "Thus says the Lord against the Philistines" (Brenton, modernized).
- b (47:4) Caphtor, probably Crete or the Aegean region, from which the Philistines were said to have come (Amos 9:7). The Septuagint does not name Caphtor, reading "the remaining inhabitants of the islands" (Brenton 29:4).
- c (47:5) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "the remnant of the Enakim" (Brenton), that is, the Anakim. Item for scholarly review.
- d (47:7) So the Septuagint and other ancient versions; the Hebrew reads "How can you be quiet."

Chapter 48

1 Concerning Moab.[a]
So says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel:
"Woe to Nebo, for it is laid waste!
Kiriathaim is put to shame, it is captured;
the stronghold[b] is put to shame and shattered.
2 Moab's renown is no more;
in Heshbon they plotted harm against her:[c]
'Come, let us cut her off from being a nation!'
You too, O Madmen, will be struck dumb;
after you the sword will go.
3 Hark! A cry from Horonaim:
'Devastation and great ruin!'
4 Moab is broken;
her little ones have made their cry heard.
5 For up the ascent of Luhith
they go weeping, weeping as they climb;
for on the descent of Horonaim
they have heard the anguished cry of ruin.
6 Flee! Save your lives!
Be like a juniper in the wilderness.[d]

7 For because you trusted in your works and your treasures,
you also will be captured;
and Chemosh[e] will go out into exile,
his priests and his officials together.
8 A destroyer will enter every town,
and not one will get away;
the valley will be ruined and the plateau devastated,
just as Yahweh has said.
9 Give wings to Moab,[f]
for she must fly away;
her towns will become a desolation,
with none to dwell in them.
10 Cursed is he who does Yahweh's work with slackness,
and cursed is he who holds back his sword from blood.
11 "At ease has Moab been from his youth,
settled on his dregs;
he has not been poured from vessel to vessel,
nor has he gone into exile;
so his flavor has stayed in him,
and his scent is unchanged.
12 Therefore look, days are coming, declares Yahweh,
when I will send him pourers who will pour him out;
they will empty his vessels
and smash their jars.[g]
13 Then Moab will be ashamed of Chemosh,
as the house of Israel was ashamed of Bethel, their confidence.[h]
14 "How can you say, 'We are warriors,
mighty men for battle'?
15 The destroyer of Moab and her towns has come up,
and the pick of his young men have gone down to the slaughter,
declares the King, whose name is Yahweh of Armies.
16 The calamity of Moab is near at hand,
and his disaster hastens swiftly.
17 Mourn him, every neighbor of his,
every one acquainted with his fame;

cry, ‘Alas, snapped is the sturdy rod,
the splendid staff!’
18 Come down from your glory
and sit on the parched ground,
O inhabitant, daughter of Dibon!
For the destroyer of Moab has come up against you;
he has ruined your fortresses.
19 Stand beside the road and watch,
you who live in Aroer!
Question the man who is running away and the woman who is escaping;
ask, ‘What happened?’
20 Moab is put to shame, for it is broken;
wail and cry out!
Tell it by the Arnon
that Moab is laid waste.
21 “Judgment has come upon the plateau, upon Holon, Jahzah, and Mephaath,
22 upon Dibon, Nebo, and Beth-diblathaim,
23 upon Kiriathaim, Beth-gamul, and Beth-meon,
24 upon Kerioth and Bozrah, and upon all the towns of the land of Moab, far and near.
25 The horn of Moab is cut off,
and his arm is broken, declares Yahweh.
26 “Make him drunk,
for he magnified himself against Yahweh;
let Moab wallow in his vomit,
and he too shall become a laughingstock.
27 Was Israel not an object of ridicule to you?
Was he found among thieves,
so that each time you mentioned him
you shook your head?
28 Quit the towns; make your home among the cliffs,
you dwellers of Moab!

Become like a dove that builds
on the far walls of a ravine's mouth.
29 We have heard of the pride of Moab—
very proud is he—
of his loftiness, his pride, his arrogance,
and the haughtiness of his heart.
30 I know his insolence, declares Yahweh;
his boasts are false,
his deeds are false.
31 Therefore I wail for Moab;
for all Moab I cry out;
for the men of Kir-heres[i] one moans.
32 Beyond the weeping for Jazer I weep for you,
vine of Sibmah!
Over the sea your shoots stretched out;
to Jazer's sea[j] they extended;
onto your ripe summer fruit and your grape harvest
the ravager has pounced.
33 Gone, swept off, are glee and merriment
from the orchard land, from Moab's land;
wine from the vats I have stopped;
no treader tramples with a cheer;
the cheer is no harvest cheer.
34 Heshbon cries, and to Elealeh,
to Jahaz, their voices carry,
from Zoar to Horonaim and to Eglath-shelishiyah;
for Nimrim's waters too
are turned to wasteland.
35 And I will bring to an end in Moab, declares Yahweh,
him who offers on the high place
and burns incense to his god.
36 Therefore my heart moans for Moab like flutes,
and my heart moans like flutes for the men of Kir-heres;
therefore the riches they gained have perished.

37 Yes, shorn is every head,
trimmed short is every beard;
cuts on every hand,
on every waist sackcloth.
38 On all of Moab's rooftops and in its public squares
there is only mourning;
for I have smashed Moab
like a jar nobody wants, declares Yahweh.
39 Shattered—how they howl!
Moab—how he turns tail in disgrace!
A mockery Moab has turned into,
a terror to all his neighbors."
40 For so says Yahweh:
"Look, one will swoop like an eagle
and spread his wings over Moab.[k]
41 Kerioth[l] is captured,
and the strongholds are seized.
The heart of Moab's warriors on that day
will be like the heart of a woman in labor.
42 Moab will be destroyed from being a people,
because he magnified himself against Yahweh.
43 Terror, pit, and trap[m]
are upon you, O inhabitant of Moab,
declares Yahweh.
44 The one fleeing from terror
tumbles into the pit;
the one clambering up out of the pit
is caught fast by the trap.
For this I will bring on Moab—
their year of reckoning, declares Yahweh.
45 "In the shelter of Heshbon
the refugees stand powerless;[n]
for a fire has blazed from Heshbon,
a flame from Sihon's house;

it has burned up Moab's brow,
the skulls of the noisy sons of battle.
46 Woe to you, O Moab!
The people of Chemosh are undone;
for your sons have been taken captive,
and your daughters into captivity.
47 Yet I will restore the fortunes of Moab
in the latter days, declares Yahweh."
Thus far the judgment on Moab.

Notes

- a (48:1) Moab lay east of the Dead Sea. Much of this oracle parallels Isaiah 15–16, and verses 45–46 parallel Numbers 21:28–29; 24:17.
- b (48:1) Or "Misgab," a place-name.
- c (48:2) Hebrew beḥeshbon ḥashevu, a play on the name Heshbon ("reckoning") and the verb "plot." "Madmen" (a town) likewise plays on tiddommi, "you will be silenced."
- d (48:6) Or "like Aroer"; the Septuagint reads "as a wild donkey in the desert" (Brenton, modernized).
- e (48:7) Chemosh, the national god of Moab. The Septuagint spells it "Chamos" (Brenton).
- f (48:9) Hebrew tsits, usually "flower" or "wing"; the meaning is uncertain (perhaps "salt" or "a gravestone"). The Septuagint reads "Set marks upon Moab" (Brenton).
- g (48:12) The image is of wine settled on its lees, now poured off by "tilters" who tip the jars.
- h (48:13) Bethel may be the town of the northern sanctuary or the name of a deity known from other ancient sources.
- i (48:31) Kir-heres, "wall of potsherds," probably the Moabite capital Kir-hareseth (Isaiah 16:7, 11).
- j (48:32) Some Hebrew manuscripts and Isaiah 16:8 lack "sea of"; the text is uncertain.
- k (48:40) The Septuagint lacks the eagle image here and the second half of verse 41 (Brenton 31:40–41); compare 49:22.
- l (48:41) Or "The towns." Kerioth may be a place-name or the plural "towns."
- m (48:43) Hebrew paḥad wapaḥath wapaḥ, a sound play. Compare Isaiah 24:17–18.
- n (48:45) Verses 45–47 are absent from the Septuagint (Brenton).

Chapter 49

1 About the Ammonites.[a]
This is what Yahweh says:

"Does Israel have no children?
No one to inherit?
Then why has Milcom[b] taken over Gad,
and his people moved into its towns?
2 For this reason, look, the time is coming, declares Yahweh,
when I will sound the war cry
against Rabbah of the Ammonites;
it will become a ruined heap,
and its surrounding villages will be set ablaze;
then Israel will take the land from those who took it from him,
says Yahweh.
3 Howl, Heshbon—Ai lies ravaged!
Shriek, you daughters of Rabbah!
Wrap on sackcloth, keen,
dart back and forth among the walled pens!
For off to captivity Milcom marches,
his priests with his chiefs alongside.
4 Why do you boast of your valleys,
your valley flowing,[c] O faithless daughter,
who trusted in her treasures, saying,
'Who will come against me?'
5 Look, I am bringing terror upon you,
declares Lord Yahweh of Armies,
from all who are around you;
you will be driven out, each straight ahead,
with none to gather the fugitives.
6 Yet later the lot of Ammon's people I will turn back again,
is Yahweh's utterance."[d]
7 Concerning Edom.[e]
So says Yahweh of Armies:
"Is wisdom no more in Teman?
Has counsel perished from the prudent?
Has their wisdom gone stale?
8 Flee, turn back, dwell in the depths,
O inhabitants of Dedan!

For I will bring the calamity of Esau upon him,
the time when I punish him.
9 If grape pickers came to you,
wouldn't they leave some grapes behind?
If thieves came at night,
they would take only as much as they wanted.[f]
10 But I have stripped Esau bare;
I have exposed his hiding places,
so that he cannot hide.
His descendants, relatives and neighbors are wiped out,
and he is gone.
11 Abandon your fatherless; I myself will preserve them;
on me let your bereaved wives rely."
12 This is what Yahweh says: "Look, those who did not deserve to drink the cup will have to drink it; and will you be the one to escape without any punishment? You will not escape; you will certainly drink.
13 For by myself I have sworn, declares Yahweh, that Bozrah[g] will become a horror, a reproach, a waste, and a curse, and all her towns will be perpetual wastes."
14 I have heard a message from Yahweh,
and a messenger has been sent to the nations:
"Assemble and march against her,
and get ready for battle!"
15 "For look, I will make you small among the nations,
despised among mankind.
16 The fear you cause has fooled you,
along with your proud heart,
you who live in the rock crevices,[h]
who occupy the mountaintop.
Even if you build your nest as high as an eagle's,
I will pull you down from there,
declares Yahweh.
17 Edom will become an object of horror;
all who pass by will be shocked
and whistle at all its injuries.

18 As happened at the toppling of Sodom and Gomorrah with their
adjoining towns, Yahweh says,
not one person will reside there;
no mortal will so much as camp in her.
19 See, as a lion climbs out of Jordan's jungle
toward an ever-green grazing ground,
in a moment I will chase him off it,
and whoever I pick I will set in charge of it.
Who compares with me? Who will call me to court?
Which shepherd can hold his ground before my face?"
20 So hear the plan Yahweh has devised against Edom
and the intentions he has toward the people of Teman:
the youngest of the flock will certainly be dragged off;
their pasture will certainly be horrified at their fate.
21 At the sound of their fall the earth shakes;
the cry—at the Red Sea[i] its sound is heard.
22 Mark it: as an eagle mounts and plunges,
so one spreads wide his feathers above Bozrah;
the hearts of Edom's champions in that hour
will flutter like a woman's in childbirth.
23 About Damascus.
"Disgraced are Hamath and Arpad,
for an evil report has reached their ears;
they dissolve with dread; at the sea is turmoil;[j]
it can find no rest.
24 Damascus has grown feeble; she turns to flee,
and panic has seized her;
anguish and pangs have taken hold of her,
like a woman in labor.
25 How is the city of praise not forsaken,[k]
the town of my joy?
26 Because of this her young men will fall in her public squares,
and all her warriors will be quiet on that day,
declares Yahweh of Armies.

27 And I will kindle a fire in the wall of Damascus,
and it will consume the strongholds of Ben-hadad."[l]
28 Concerning Kedar and the kingdoms of Hazor,[m] which Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon struck down.
So says Yahweh:
"Rise up, go up against Kedar!
Destroy the people of the east!
29 Tents and flocks will be seized from them,
their tent hangings and every article;
camels they will lead off as their own,
shouting over them, 'Dread all around!'
30 Run! Roam far away! Make your homes deep down,
dwellers of Hazor, is Yahweh's utterance!
For Babylon's king Nebuchadrezzar has devised a scheme against you,
contrived a design against you.
31 Arise, march against a nation lounging at ease,
untroubled in its living, is Yahweh's utterance,
a people without door or bolt,
encamped apart from all.
32 Plunder their camels will be,
their droves of cattle booty.
To every wind I will fling the ones with trimmed temples,[n]
and from all quarters I will fetch their ruin, declares Yahweh.
33 Hazor will become a lair for jackals,
a permanent wasteland;
nobody will live there,
no person will stay in it."
34 The word of Yahweh that came to Jeremiah the prophet concerning Elam,[o] at the beginning of the reign of Zedekiah king of Judah:
35 So says Yahweh of Armies:
"Look, I am breaking the bow of Elam,
the chief of their might.
36 I will bring four winds against Elam
from the four corners of the sky,

and scatter them in every direction;
there will be no nation
that Elam's exiles do not reach.
37 I will break Elam in front of its enemies
and in front of those who want its life;
I will bring disaster on them,
my burning anger, declares Yahweh;
I will send the sword after them
until I have finished them off.
38 In Elam I will set up my seat of rule;
king and princes I will abolish thence,
is Yahweh's utterance.
39 Yet when the final days come
Elam's captivity I will turn around,
is Yahweh's utterance."

Notes

- a (49:1) Ammon lay northeast of Moab, with its capital at Rabbah (modern Amman). In the Septuagint the Ammon oracle follows those on Edom (Brenton 30:17–22).
- b (49:1) Milcom, the god of the Ammonites (1 Kings 11:5). The Hebrew vowels read malkam, "their king"; the Septuagint has "Melchol" (Brenton).
- c (49:4) Or "your ebbing valley"; the Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint reads "the plains of the Enakim" (Brenton).
- d (49:6) Verse 6 is absent from the Septuagint (Brenton).
- e (49:7) Edom, south of the Dead Sea, descended from Esau. Verses 9–10 and 14–16 closely parallel Obadiah 1–6.
- f (49:9) Or "would they not destroy only what was enough for them?"
- g (49:13) Bozrah, a chief city of Edom.
- h (49:16) Hebrew sela, perhaps also a play on the city Sela (2 Kings 14:7).
- i (49:21) Hebrew Yam Suph, "Sea of Reeds."
- j (49:23) Or "there is anxiety like the sea."
- k (49:25) Or "How the city of praise has been forsaken!" Some versions lack "not."
- l (49:27) Ben-hadad, "son of Hadad," a name borne by several Aramean kings of Damascus.
- m (49:28) Kedar, an Arabian tribe; Hazor here is probably a region of village settlements (Hebrew ḥatser), not the city in Galilee. The Septuagint reads "Kedar the Queen of the Palace" (Brenton).
- n (49:32) Or "who shave their temples." Compare 9:26; 25:23.

- o (49:34) Elam, east of Babylonia. In the Septuagint this oracle comes first among the oracles against the nations, after 25:13 (Brenton 25:14–20), with the date at its end.

Chapter 50

1 The word that Yahweh spoke concerning Babylon, concerning the land of the Chaldeans, by the hand of Jeremiah the prophet:[a]

2 "Declare among the nations and proclaim it;
raise a signal flag, proclaim it, do not hide it;
say: 'Babylon is captured,
Bel[b] is put to shame,
Merodach is shattered;
her images are put to shame,
her idols[c] are shattered.'

3 For from the north a people climbs up to attack her;
her country it will turn to waste,
with no one living there;
human and animal alike have bolted and vanished.

4 "In those days and at that time, declares Yahweh,
the people of Israel will come,
they and the people of Judah together,
weeping as they come,
and Yahweh their God they will seek.

5 They will ask the way to Zion,
with their faces turned toward it, saying,
'Come, let us join ourselves to Yahweh
in an everlasting covenant that will never be forgotten.'

6 My people have been lost sheep;
their shepherds led them astray,
turning them loose on the mountains;
from mountain to hill they went;
they forgot their fold.

7 All who found them devoured them,
and their foes said, 'We are not guilty,

because they sinned against Yahweh, the pasture of righteousness,
Yahweh, the hope of their fathers.'
8 "Flee from the midst of Babylon,
go out from the land of the Chaldeans,
and be like male goats before the flock.
9 For look, I am rousing and sending against Babylon
a coalition of great nations from the northern country;
they will line up against her;
from that direction she will be captured.
Their arrows are like those of a skilled[d] warrior
who never returns with nothing.
10 Chaldea will be loot;
her looters will all eat their fill, declares Yahweh.
11 "Exult you may, celebrate you may,
you pillagers of my inheritance;
skip you may like a calf on the threshing ground,
whinny you may like warhorses,
12 your mother will be deeply ashamed;
the one who gave birth to you will be humiliated.
Look, she will be the least of the nations,
an empty, parched wilderness.
13 Because of Yahweh's wrath she will not be inhabited
but will be wholly desolate;
everyone who passes by Babylon will be appalled
and hiss because of all her wounds.
14 Array yourselves against Babylon all around,
all you who bend the bow;
shoot at her; spare no arrows,
for she has sinned against Yahweh.
15 Shout against her from every side:
she has surrendered;[e]
her towers have fallen;
her walls have been torn down.
This is Yahweh's revenge:

get revenge on her;
treat her as she has treated others.
16 Wipe out of Babylon the one who sows
and the one who swings the sickle at harvest time;
because of the oppressing sword[f]
everyone will go back to his own people,
and everyone will run to his own country.
17 "Israel is a scattered sheep,
driven away by lions.
First the king of Assyria devoured him,
and now at last Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon has gnawed his bones.
18 Therefore so says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel:
Look, I am punishing the king of Babylon and his land,
as I punished the king of Assyria.
19 I will return Israel to his own grazing land,
and he will feed on Carmel and Bashan,
and his hunger will be satisfied
on the hills of Ephraim and in Gilead.
20 In those days and at that time, declares Yahweh,
iniquity will be sought in Israel, and there will be none,
and sins in Judah, and none will be found;
for I will pardon those whom I leave as a remnant.
21 "Attack the land of Merathaim,[g]
attack it and those who live in Pekod;
kill them and destroy them completely, declares Yahweh,
and do everything I have ordered you.
22 The sound of battle is in the land,
and great destruction!
23 Ah, the sledge that pounded all the world—
hacked off, splintered!
Ah, Babylon—a thing of horror
in the eyes of the peoples!
24 A trap I laid for you, Babylon, and you were snared
before you were aware;

discovered you were, and gripped,
since against Yahweh you picked a fight.
25 Yahweh has opened his storehouse
and taken out the weapons of his fury,
for the Lord Yahweh of Armies has a task
in the land of the Chaldeans.
26 Close in on her from the remotest edge;
break open her storehouses;
heap her like sheaves, and put her under the ban;
leave her no remainder.
27 Kill all her bulls;
let them go down to the slaughter.
Woe to them, for their day has come,
the time of their punishment.
28 "Hark! Fugitives and escapees from the land of Babylon,
to declare in Zion
the vengeance of Yahweh our God,
vengeance for his temple.[h]
29 Call up bowmen to Babylon,
every one who draws the bow;
pitch camp on every side of her;
allow no one to slip out.
Pay her back for her conduct;
the way she acted, act toward her;
for against Yahweh she was insolent,
against Israel's Holy One.
30 So her young men will fall in her public squares,
and all her warriors will be silenced on that day, declares Yahweh.
31 Look, I am against you, O Arrogance,[i]
declares Lord Yahweh of Armies,
for your day has come,
the time when I punish you.
32 The arrogant one will trip and fall,
and no one will lift him up;

I will set his towns on fire,
and it will burn up everything around him.
33 "Yahweh of Armies says this:
Crushed are Israel's people,
and Judah's people along with them;
their captors all clutch them tight;
they will not release them.
34 But their Redeemer is strong;
his name is Yahweh of Armies.
He will certainly take up their case,
bringing rest to the earth
but turmoil to the people of Babylon.
35 Sword upon the Chaldeans, declares Yahweh,
upon those who live in Babylon,
upon her princes and upon her sages!
36 Sword upon the babblers,[j] so that they turn foolish!
Sword upon her heroes, so that they shatter with fear!
37 A sword against her horses and her chariots,
and against all the mixed peoples in her midst,
that they may become like women!
A sword against her treasures, that they may be plundered!
38 Parching[k] upon her waters, so that they dry up!
For hers is a country of carved figures,
and over monstrous idols they rave.
39 Therefore desert creatures with jackals will dwell there,
and ostriches will dwell in her;
she will never again be inhabited
or settled from generation to generation.[l]
40 As when God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah and their neighbors, declares Yahweh,
no one will dwell there,
no human being will sojourn in her.
41 "Look, a people is coming from the north,
a great nation and many kings
stirred up from the farthest parts of the earth.[m]

42 They are armed with bow and spear;
they are cruel and merciless.
Their roar sounds like the sea;
they ride horses,
all in line like one man for battle
against you, daughter of Babylon!
43 The king of Babylon heard the report of them,
and his hands fell limp;
anguish seized him,
pain like a woman in labor.
44 "See, as a lion climbs from the jungle of the Jordan
toward an ever-green grazing ground,[n]
in a moment I will chase them off it,
and whoever I pick I will set in charge of it.
Who compares with me? Who will call me to court?
Which shepherd can hold his ground before my face?
45 Therefore hear the plan that Yahweh has made against Babylon
and the purposes he has formed against the land of the Chaldeans:
surely the little ones of the flock will be dragged away;
surely their pasture will be appalled at them.
46 At the sound of the capture of Babylon the earth shakes,
and a cry is heard among the nations."

Notes

- a (50:1) The Septuagint begins simply "The word of the Lord which he spoke against Babylon" (Brenton, modernized). Chapters 50–51 form the longest oracle in the book; in the Septuagint they are chapters 27–28 (Brenton).
- b (50:2) Bel ("lord") and Merodach (Babylonian Marduk) are titles of the chief god of Babylon. The Septuagint reads "Belus is confounded; the fearless, the luxurious Maerodach is delivered up" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (50:2) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous term, perhaps "dung pellets."
- d (50:9) So many manuscripts and ancient versions; other Hebrew manuscripts read "a bereaving."
- e (50:15) That is, surrendered.
- f (50:16) Or "the sword of the dove." The Septuagint reads "the Grecian sword" (Brenton), taking hayyonah as Yawan, "Greece."
- g (50:21) Merathaim ("double rebellion") and Pekod ("punishment") are wordplays on Babylonian place-names, Mat Marratim (the marsh region of southern Baby-

lonia) and the Puqudu people. The Septuagint lacks both names, reading "Go up against it roughly" (Brenton).

- h (50:28) The Septuagint lacks "vengeance for his temple" (compare Brenton 27:28).
- i (50:31) Hebrew zadon, personified.
- j (50:36) Hebrew baddim, "empty talkers," that is, oracle priests.
- k (50:38) Hebrew ḥorev, a sound play on ḥerev, "sword," in verses 35–37. Some read "sword" here too.
- l (50:39) Compare Isaiah 13:20–22; 34:13–15.
- m (50:41) Verses 41–43 adapt 6:22–24, once spoken against Zion, now against Babylon.
- n (50:44) Verses 44–46 adapt 49:19–21, once spoken against Edom.

Chapter 51

1 This is what Yahweh says:
"Look, I am rousing a destroying spirit
against Babylon
and the people of Leb-kamai.[a]
2 And I will send to Babylon winnowers,
and they will winnow her
and empty her land,
for they will be against her on every side
in the day of disaster.
3 Against the one who strings the bow let the archer string his,[b]
against the one who struts in his mail.
Show no pity to her youths;
put her whole host under the ban.
4 They will fall slain in the land of the Chaldeans,
pierced through in her streets.
5 For Israel and Judah have not been widowed
by their God, by Yahweh of Armies,
though their land is full of guilt
against the Holy One of Israel.
6 Run away from Babylon;
everyone must save his own life!
Do not die because of her guilt,
for this is the time of Yahweh's revenge;
he is giving her what she deserves.

7 A golden cup was Babylon in the hand of Yahweh,
making all the earth drunk;
the nations drank of her wine;
therefore the nations went mad.
8 Suddenly Babylon has fallen and is shattered;
wail for her!
Take balm for her pain;
perhaps she may be healed.
9 We tried to heal Babylon,
but she could not be healed.
Leave her, and let each of us go
back to his own country,
for her sentence reaches the sky
and rises as high as the clouds.
10 Yahweh has brought forth our vindication;
come, let us tell in Zion
the work of Yahweh our God.
11 "Sharpen the arrows!
Fill the quivers![c]
Yahweh has stirred up the spirit of the kings of the Medes,[d]
for his purpose concerning Babylon is to destroy it;
for it is the vengeance of Yahweh,
vengeance for his temple.
12 Raise a battle flag against Babylon's walls;
reinforce the guard;
station the watchmen;
prepare the ambushes;
for Yahweh has planned and also carried out
what he said about the people of Babylon.
13 O you who dwell by many waters,
rich in treasures,
your end has come,
the measure of your unjust gain.[e]

14 Yahweh of Armies has sworn by himself:
‘Surely I will fill you with men, as with locusts,
and they will raise the shout of victory over you.’
15 “He made the earth by his power,
established the world by his wisdom,
and by his understanding stretched out the heavens.[f]
16 At the sound of his thunder the waters overhead clamor,
and vapors climb at his bidding from earth’s far rim.
Lightning flashes he fashions to go with the rain,
and from his treasure chambers he releases the gale.
17 Every man is stupid, without knowledge;
every goldsmith is put to shame by his idol,
for his cast image is a lie,
and there is no breath in them.
18 Hollow puffs they are, a laughable craft;
when their reckoning comes they will vanish.
19 Unlike these is Jacob’s Share,
since it is he who shaped everything,
and Israel is the clan he claims as his own;[g]
Yahweh of Armies—that is his name.
20 “A mace you are for me,[h] a tool of war:
by you I smash peoples;
by you I bring realms to ruin;
21 with you I shatter the horse and its rider;
with you I shatter the chariot and its driver;
22 by you I smash husband and wife;
by you I smash the aged and the lad;
by you I smash the youth and the maiden;
23 by you I smash herdsman and herd;
by you I smash plowman and yoke of oxen;
by you I smash prefects and deputies.
24 Yet Babylon and every resident of Chaldea I will pay back
for every wicked act of theirs committed in Zion—
with your own eyes watching, declares Yahweh.

25 “See, I stand against you, mountain of ruin, declares Yahweh,
you that ruin all the world;
my hand I will reach out at you,
tumble you off the cliffs,
and turn you into a mountain of cinders.
26 No stone will be taken from you for a corner,
nor any stone for a foundation,
but you will be a perpetual desolation, declares Yahweh.
27 “Raise a signal flag in the land;
blow the ram’s horn among the nations;
consecrate nations against her;
summon kingdoms against her,
Ararat, Minni, and Ashkenaz;[i]
appoint a marshal against her;
bring up horses like bristling locusts.
28 Consecrate nations against her,
the kings of the Medes,
their governors and all their commanders,
and every land under their dominion.
29 The land quakes and writhes,
for Yahweh’s purposes against Babylon stand,
to make the land of Babylon a desolation
with no inhabitant.
30 The warriors of Babylon have ceased fighting;
they sit in their strongholds;
their strength has dried up;
they have become like women.
Her dwellings are set on fire;
her bars are broken.
31 Runner runs to meet runner,
and messenger to meet messenger,
to tell the king of Babylon
that his city is captured from end to end;

32 the fords have been seized,
the reed marshes[j] burned with fire,
and the soldiers are terrified.
33 For so says Yahweh of Armies, God of Israel:
The daughter of Babylon is like a threshing floor
at the time it is trodden;
yet a little while
and the time of her harvest will come.
34 "He has eaten me up, Nebuchadrezzar, Babylon's king;[k]
he has thrown me into confusion;
he has left me standing like a jar drained dry;
like a dragon he has gulped me down;
with my choice morsels he has stuffed his stomach;
he has flushed me away.
35 'May the violence done to me and my body fall on Babylon,'
let the people of Zion say.
'May my blood fall on those who live in Chaldea,'
let Jerusalem say.
36 Therefore so says Yahweh:
Look, I will plead your cause
and take vengeance for you.
I will dry up her sea
and make her fountain dry,
37 and Babylon will become a heap of ruins,
a haunt of jackals,
a horror and a hissing,
without inhabitant.[l]
38 Together they roar like lions;
they growl like lions' cubs.
39 While they are heated I will set out their feast
and make them drunk, that they may revel,
then sleep a perpetual sleep
and not wake, declares Yahweh.
40 I will bring them down like lambs to the slaughter,
like rams and male goats.

41 “How Sheshach[m] is captured,
the praise of the whole earth seized!
How Babylon has become a horror
among the nations!
42 The sea has come up over Babylon;
she is covered by its roaring waves.
43 Her cities are turned to ruin,
a parched country, a steppe,
a country where nobody lives,
which no human being crosses.
44 Bel I will punish in Babylon,
and make him spit up what he gulped.
No longer will peoples flow to him like a river;
yes, Babylon’s wall is down.
45 “Go out of her midst, my people![n]
Let each one save his life
from the fierce anger of Yahweh!
46 Let your courage not sink,
nor be frightened by rumors heard around the land,
when one rumor arrives this year,
and next year yet another rumor,
with brutality throughout the land,
one ruler set against another.
47 For this reason, see, the days approach
when Babylon’s carved gods I will call to account;
her entire country will be disgraced,
and all her fallen will lie inside her.
48 Then sky and earth with everything in them
will sing aloud over Babylon,
since from the north her ravagers will arrive,
declares Yahweh.
49 For Israel’s slain Babylon herself must topple,
as by Babylon’s doing the slain of all the earth toppled.
50 “You who have escaped the sword,
go, do not stand still!

Remember Yahweh from far away,
and let Jerusalem come into your mind:
51 'We are put to shame, for we have heard reproach;
disgrace has covered our faces,
for foreigners have entered
the holy places of the house of Yahweh.'
52 Therefore look, days are coming, declares Yahweh,
when I will punish her images,
and through all her land the wounded will groan.
53 Though Babylon should mount up to heaven,
and though she should fortify her lofty stronghold,
from me destroyers would come upon her,
declares Yahweh.
54 "Hark! A cry from Babylon!
Great destruction from the land of the Chaldeans!
55 For Yahweh is laying Babylon waste
and silencing her great noise;
their waves roar like many waters;
the din of their voice resounds.
56 Yes, a ravager has reached her—Babylon;
captured are her champions;
snapped are their bows;
for a God who requites is Yahweh;
full payment he will exact.
57 I will make her officials and wise men drunk,
her governors, deputies and warriors;
they will sleep a never-ending sleep and not get up,
declares the King, whose name is Yahweh of Armies.
58 "Yahweh of Armies declares this:
Babylon's wide rampart
will be razed flat,
and her towering gates
set ablaze.
So peoples toil in vain,
and nations wear themselves out just to feed the flames."[o]

59 This is the message the prophet Jeremiah gave to Seraiah[p] son of
Neriah, the son of Mahseiah, when Seraiah went to Babylon with
Zedekiah king of Judah in the fourth year of Zedekiah's reign. Seraiah
was the officer in charge of arranging camp.[q]
60 Jeremiah wrote in one scroll all the disaster that would come upon
Babylon, all these words that are written concerning Babylon.
61 Jeremiah told Seraiah, "When you get to Babylon, make sure you
read all these words aloud,
62 and say, 'O Yahweh, you have spoken concerning this place, to cut
it off, so that nothing will dwell in it, neither man nor beast, and it
will be a perpetual desolation.'
63 Once you have read the scroll to the end, fasten a stone to it and
fling it into the Euphrates' midstream,
64 then say, 'In this way Babylon will go under, never to surface again,
because of the ruin I am bringing on her; and they will be worn out.'"[r]

To this point the words of Jeremiah extend.

Notes

- a (51:1) Leb-kamai, literally "the heart of those who rise against me," is an atbash cipher for Kasdim, "Chaldeans" (each letter replaced by its mirror in the alphabet, as with Sheshach; see 25:26). The Septuagint reads simply "against the Chaldeans dwelling therein" (Brenton, modernized). Item for scholarly review.
- b (51:3) So the Hebrew consonants, which repeat "bend"; the Hebrew vowels and some ancient versions read instead "Let not the archer bend his bow, nor rise up in his armor." The text is difficult.
- c (51:11) Or "Take up the shields."
- d (51:11) The Medes, from northwestern Iran, joined in the overthrow of Assyria and later formed part of the Persian empire that took Babylon in 539 B.C.
- e (51:13) Hebrew "the cubit (ammah) of your cutting off," an idiom for the measure of a life or gain; the sense is uncertain.
- f (51:15) Verses 15–19 repeat 10:12–16.
- g (51:19) So many Hebrew manuscripts and 10:16; the Hebrew here lacks "Israel is."
- h (51:20) Hebrew mappets, "shatterer." The speaker addresses Babylon (or possibly Cyrus); the verb "shatter" (napats) is repeated nine times.
- i (51:27) Ararat (Urartu, near Lake Van), Minni (the Mannaeans), and Ashkenaz (the Scythians) were peoples to the north. The Septuagint reads "by me, and that for the people of Achanaz" (Brenton, modernized).
- j (51:32) Hebrew agammim, "pools" or "reed thickets."
- k (51:34) So the Qere; the Kethib reads "us" throughout this verse. Zion speaks here.

- l (51:37) Verse 37 is shortened in the Septuagint: "And Babylon shall be a desolation, and shall not be inhabited" (Brenton).
- m (51:41) Sheshach is an atbash cipher for Babel (Babylon); see 25:26. The Septuagint lacks the name here, reading "How has the boast of all the earth been taken" (Brenton, modernized). Item for scholarly review.
- n (51:45) Verses 45–48 are absent from the Septuagint, and verse 49 there begins "and in Babylon the slain men of all the earth shall fall" (Brenton).
- o (51:58) Compare Habakkuk 2:13. The Septuagint reverses the sense: "and the peoples shall not labor in vain, nor the nations fail in their rule" (Brenton, modernized).
- p (51:59) Seraiah, "Yahweh is prince," was the brother of Baruch (compare 32:12). The Septuagint reads "when he went from Zedekiah" (Brenton, modernized), suggesting an embassy sent by the king rather than the king himself making the journey.
- q (51:59) Hebrew sar menuḥah, "officer of the resting place," that is, in charge of the king's lodgings on the march. The Septuagint reads "over the bounties" (Brenton), taking it as minḥah, "gift" or "tribute."
- r (51:64) The Septuagint lacks "and they will be worn out" and the closing line about the words of Jeremiah (Brenton 28:64). The words "they will be worn out" repeat the end of verse 58 and may have marked the end of the oracle before chapter 52, a historical appendix, was added.

Chapter 52

1 Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he became king, and he
reigned eleven years in Jerusalem.[a] His mother's name was Hamutal
daughter of Jeremiah of Libnah. 2 He did what was evil in the eyes
of Yahweh, just as Jehoiakim had done.[b] 3 Yahweh's anger was the
reason this happened to Jerusalem and Judah, until he threw them
out of his sight. Zedekiah then rebelled against the king of Babylon.
4 In the ninth year of Zedekiah's reign, on the tenth day of the
tenth month (December–January),[c] Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon
marched against Jerusalem with his whole army; they set up camp
around it and built siege works on every side. 5 The siege of the city
lasted right up to King Zedekiah's eleventh year. 6 In the fourth month
(in June–July),[d] on the ninth day of the month, the famine became
severe in the city, and there was no food for the people of the land.
7 Then the city was breached, and all the soldiers fled; they went out
of the city by night by way of the gate between the two walls, by the
king's garden, while the Chaldeans were all around the city; and they

went toward the Arabah.[e] 8 But the army of the Chaldeans pursued the
king and overtook Zedekiah in the plains of Jericho, and all his army
scattered from him. 9 They seized the king and brought him up to the
king of Babylon at Riblah in the land of Hamath, and he pronounced
sentence upon him. 10 The king of Babylon slaughtered the sons of
Zedekiah before his eyes; he also slaughtered all the officials of Judah
at Riblah. 11 Then he blinded the eyes of Zedekiah, bound him in
bronze shackles, and the king of Babylon brought him to Babylon and
put him in the house of custody[f] until the day of his death.
12 On the tenth day of the fifth month (July–August),[g] in the nine-
teenth year of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, Nebuzaradan the
captain of the guard, an officer serving the king of Babylon, entered
Jerusalem. 13 He set fire to Yahweh's house, the royal palace and all
the houses of Jerusalem; he burned down every large building. 14 And
all the army of the Chaldeans who were with the captain of the guard
broke down all the walls around Jerusalem. 15 Some of the poorest of
the people, and the rest of the people who were left in the city, and
the deserters who had gone over to the king of Babylon, and the rest
of the craftsmen, Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard carried into
exile.[h] 16 But Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard left some of the
poorest of the land to be vinedressers and plowmen.
17 The Chaldeans smashed the bronze pillars of Yahweh's house, along
with the stands and the bronze basin called the Sea in Yahweh's
house, and carried all the bronze to Babylon. 18 They also took away
the pots, the shovels, the snuffers, the basins, the ladles, and all
the bronze vessels used in the temple service. 19 The captain of the
guard also took the bowls, fire pans, basins, pots, lampstands, ladles
and drink-offering bowls—everything made of gold or silver. 20 The
bronze of the two pillars, the Sea, the twelve bronze bulls under it,[i]
and the stands that King Solomon had made for Yahweh's house was
too heavy to weigh. 21 As for the pillars, the height of each pillar
was twenty-seven feet,[j] and a cord of eighteen feet would go around
it; its thickness was about three inches; it was hollow. 22 A bronze
capital stood on top, seven and a half feet high,[k] with a network and
pomegranates around the capital, all bronze; the second pillar was the

same, with its pomegranates. 23 There were ninety-six pomegranates
on the sides;[l] all the pomegranates on the latticework all around
numbered one hundred.
24 The captain of the guard took Seraiah the chief priest, Zephaniah
the second priest, and the three keepers of the threshold; 25 From the
city, too, he removed a eunuch who had charge over the fighting
men, seven of those admitted to the king's presence[m] who turned up
in the city, the army commander's scribe who enlisted the populace
for war, and sixty of the common people discovered inside the city. 26
Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard took them and brought them
to the king of Babylon at Riblah. 27 And the king of Babylon struck
them down and put them to death at Riblah in the land of Hamath.
So Judah went into exile from its land.
28 This is the number of the people whom Nebuchadrezzar carried
into exile:[n] in the seventh year, 3,023 Judeans; 29 in the eighteenth
year of Nebuchadrezzar, 832 persons from Jerusalem; 30 in the twenty-
third year of Nebuchadrezzar, Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard
carried into exile 745 Judeans; all the persons were 4,600.
31 In the thirty-seventh year of the exile of Jehoiachin king of Judah,
in the twelfth month (in February–March),[o] on the twenty-fifth day
of the month, Evil-merodach[p] king of Babylon, in the year he became
king, lifted up the head of Jehoiachin king of Judah and brought him
out of prison. 32 He spoke kindly to him and set his seat above the
seats of the kings who were with him in Babylon. 33 So Jehoiachin
put off his prison garments, and he ate bread regularly in the king's
presence all the days of his life. 34 His upkeep, a steady ration, was
supplied him by Babylon's king, each day's share on its day, till he
died—every day he lived.[q]

Notes

- a (52:1) About 597–586 B.C. Chapter 52 closely parallels 2 Kings 24:18–25:30, with differences noted below; it serves as a historical appendix showing the fulfillment of Jeremiah's words.
- b (52:2) Verses 2–3 are absent from the Septuagint (Brenton).
- c (52:4) Hebrew Tevet; January 588 B.C. The Septuagint reads "in the ninth month" (Brenton).

- d (52:6) Hebrew Tammuz; July 586 B.C. (some date it to 587). The Septuagint lacks "in the fourth month" (Brenton). See the note at 39:2.
- e (52:7) Arabah, the rift valley of the Jordan.
- f (52:11) Or "the house of punishment"; the Septuagint reads "the grinding-house" (Brenton). 2 Kings 25:7 lacks the last clause.
- g (52:12) Hebrew Av; August 586 B.C. 2 Kings 25:8 has "the seventh day." The Septuagint lacks the clause about the nineteenth year (Brenton).
- h (52:15) Verse 15 is absent from the Septuagint (Brenton).
- i (52:20) 2 Kings 25:16 lacks "the twelve bronze bulls"; the Septuagint here has "the twelve brazen oxen under the sea" (Brenton).
- j (52:21) Hebrew "eighteen cubits" (about 8.1 m); the cord was "twelve cubits" (about 5.4 m); the thickness "four fingers" (about 7.5 cm). The Septuagint reads "thirty-five cubits" for the height (Brenton).
- k (52:22) Hebrew "five cubits," about 2.25 m. 2 Kings 25:17 has "three cubits."
- l (52:23) Or "facing the winds" (toward the four directions); the meaning is uncertain.
- m (52:25) Hebrew "seven men who saw the king's face"; 2 Kings 25:19 has five.
- n (52:28) Verses 28–30 are absent from the Septuagint (Brenton) and from 2 Kings 25. The figures (597, 586, and 582 B.C.) appear to follow a different reckoning, counting Nebuchadrezzar's years from his accession, which explains why the "eighteenth year" here corresponds to the "nineteenth year" of verse 12.
- o (52:31) Hebrew Adar; March 561 B.C. 2 Kings 25:27 has "the twenty-seventh day"; the Septuagint here reads "the four and twentieth day" (Brenton).
- p (52:31) Evil-merodach, Babylonian Amel-Marduk, "man of Marduk," son of Nebuchadrezzar (562–560 B.C.). The Septuagint spells it "Ulaemadachar" and adds that he "shaved him" (Brenton).
- q (52:34) The book closes with Jehoiachin alive and honored in exile, a quiet sign of hope for the line of David. The Septuagint ends with "until the day when he died" (Brenton), lacking "all the days of his life"; compare 2 Kings 25:30.

Lamentations

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 How[a] she sits alone,[b]
the city once thronged with people!
She has become like a widow,
she who was great among the nations;
a princess among the provinces
has been put to forced labor.
2 She sobs[c] all night long,
tears streaming down her face;
among all those who loved her
not one is left to console her;
all her companions have deceived her
and turned against her.
3 Judah[d] has been carried off, afflicted
and worked hard as a slave;
she lives among foreign peoples
and has found no place to rest;
all who chased her caught her
in the tight passes.
4 Zion's highways[e] are in mourning,
with no pilgrims arriving for the festivals;
every gate of hers lies deserted;
her priests sigh;
her maidens are wretched,[f]
and as for her—bitterness.
5 Her foes[g] have become the head;
her enemies are at ease,
for Yahweh has afflicted her
for the multitude of her transgressions;

her little children have gone away,
captives before the foe.
6 From[h] the daughter of Zion has departed
all her splendor.
Her princes have become like stags
that find no pasture;
they went without strength
before the pursuer.
7 Jerusalem calls to mind,[i] in her days of misery and homelessness,
all her treasured things
that she owned in ages past.
As her people dropped into the enemy's grip,
with no one coming to her aid,
her adversaries stared at her;
they laughed at her collapse.[j]
8 Grievously[k] has Jerusalem sinned;
therefore she has become a thing unclean;[l]
all who honored her despise her,
for they have seen her nakedness;
she herself groans
and turns away.
9 Her uncleanness[m] is in her skirts;
she gave no thought to her end;
astonishingly she has come down,
with none to comfort her.
"See, O Yahweh, my affliction,
for the enemy has magnified himself!"
10 His hand[n] the adversary has thrust out
upon every treasure of hers;
for she watched the pagans
march into her holy place—
those you had forbidden
to join your congregation.[o]
11 All[p] her people groan
as they search for bread;

they give their treasures for food
to bring back life.
"See, O Yahweh, and look,
how worthless I have become!"
12 "Is it[q] nothing to you, all you who pass along the road?[r]
Look and see
if there is any pain like my pain,
which was dealt out to me,
which Yahweh inflicted
on the day of his fierce anger.
13 Out of the heights[s] he hurled fire;
down into my bones he drove it;[t]
he stretched a net to snare my feet;
he made me turn back;
he left me forlorn,
sick the whole day through.
14 My offenses[u] are fastened as a yoke;[v]
his hand has woven them together;
they have been lifted onto my neck;
he has drained my strength;
the Lord has delivered me
into the power of those I cannot resist.
15 The Lord[w] has thrown aside
every warrior among my people;
he has called a gathering to wipe out
my young men;
the Lord has stomped the grapes
of Judah's virgin daughter.
16 For these things[x] I weep;
my eye, my eye runs down with water;
for far from me is a comforter,
one to restore my life;
my children are desolate,
for the enemy has prevailed."

17 Zion[y] reaches out with her hands;
no one is there to console her;
Yahweh issued orders concerning Jacob:
those around him must be his adversaries;
Jerusalem has turned into
something defiled in their midst.
18 "Yahweh[z] is in the right,
for I defied what he commanded;[aa]
listen, all you peoples,
and look at my suffering;
my girls and my young men
have been taken prisoner.
19 I called[ab] to my lovers,
but they deceived me;
my priests and my elders
perished in the city
while they sought food for themselves
to bring back their life.
20 See,[ac] O Yahweh, for I am in distress;
my inner parts churn;
my heart is turned over within me,
for I have been very rebellious.
Outside the sword bereaves;
inside, it is like death.
21 They heard[ad] that I groan,
with none to comfort me;
all my enemies heard of my trouble;
they rejoice that you have done it.
Bring on the day you have proclaimed,
and let them be as I am.
22 May every[ae] wicked deed of theirs come into your view;
treat them harshly,
as harshly as you treated me
because of every rebellion of mine;

for many are my sighs,
and sick is my heart."

Notes

- a (1:1) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter aleph (א) (the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet).
- b (1:1) Hebrew ʾekah, "How!", the cry of a funeral dirge and the Hebrew title of the book. The Septuagint prefaces the verse: "And it came to pass, after Israel was taken captive, and Jerusalem made desolate, that Jeremiah sat weeping, and lamented with this lamentation over Jerusalem, and said" (Brenton, modernized).
- c (1:2) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter beth (ב).
- d (1:3) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter gimel (ג).
- e (1:4) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter daleth (ד).
- f (1:4) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "her virgins are led captive" (Brenton).
- g (1:5) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter he (ה).
- h (1:6) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter vav (ו).
- i (1:7) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter zayin (ז).
- j (1:7) Hebrew mishbattehah, perhaps "her cessation" or "her ruin"; the word is rare. This verse has four lines in the Hebrew where most stanzas have three couplets.
- k (1:8) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter heth (ח).
- l (1:8) Hebrew nidah, perhaps "a shaking of the head" or, by a slightly different reading, "impure," as with menstrual impurity (compare verse 17).
- m (1:9) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter teth (ט).
- n (1:10) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter yod (י).
- o (1:10) Compare Deuteronomy 23:3.
- p (1:11) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter kaph (כ).
- q (1:12) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter lamed (ל).
- r (1:12) The Hebrew is difficult; literally "Not to you," perhaps "May it not happen to you."
- s (1:13) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter mem (מ).
- t (1:13) So the Septuagint (Brenton, "he has brought it into my bones"); the Hebrew reads "and it prevailed over it."
- u (1:14) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter nun (נ).
- v (1:14) The Hebrew is uncertain; the Septuagint reads "He has watched over my sins" (Brenton).
- w (1:15) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter samekh (ס).
- x (1:16) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter ayin (ע).
- y (1:17) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter peh (פ).
- z (1:18) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tsade (צ).
- aa (1:18) Hebrew "his mouth."
- ab (1:19) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter qoph (ק).

- ac (1:20) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter resh (ר).
- ad (1:21) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter shin (ש).
- ae (1:22) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tav (ת).

Chapter 2

1 Ah, how[a] the Lord in his wrath
has wrapped daughter Zion in cloud![b]
Out of the sky to the dust he has hurled
Israel's glory;
his own footrest[c] he has put out of mind
in the day of his fury.
2 Pitilessly[d] the Lord has gulped down
every homestead of Jacob;
in his rage he has demolished
daughter Judah's fortresses;
he has leveled them to the earth;
kingdom and rulers he has desecrated.
3 In fierce anger he has chopped off[e]
all Israel's strength;
he has pulled back his right hand
when the enemy came;
he has blazed up against Jacob like a fire in flames
consuming everything near.
4 He has drawn[f] his bow like an enemy,
his right hand poised like an adversary;
he has killed everything pleasing to see
in the tent of Daughter Zion;
like fire, his rage has poured out.
5 The Lord[g] has become like an enemy;
he has swallowed up Israel;
he has swallowed up all her palaces;
he has laid waste his strongholds,
and multiplied in daughter Judah
mourning and moaning.[h]

6 He has wrecked[i] his booth like a garden;
he has laid waste his meeting place;
Yahweh has made Zion forget
appointed feast and sabbath,
and in the indignation of his anger
has spurned king and priest.
7 His altar[j] the Lord has spurned,
his holy place renounced;
into the enemy's grip he has handed over
the ramparts of her citadels;
in Yahweh's house they made an uproar
like the din of a festival day.
8 Yahweh[k] resolved to wreck
daughter Zion's wall;
he stretched the surveyor's cord;
his hand he did not draw back from ruin;
he set bulwark and wall to grieving;
both alike waste away.
9 Sunk[l] into the ground are her gates;
he has ruined and broken her bars;
her king and her princes are among the nations;
there is no instruction;[m]
her prophets also find
no vision from Yahweh.
10 Silent on the earth[n] sit
daughter Zion's elders;
dust they have tossed upon their heads;
sackcloth they have wrapped round;
Jerusalem's maidens
droop their heads to the earth.
11 My eyes[o] are spent with tears;
my inner parts churn;
my liver[p] is poured out on the ground
because of the ruin of the daughter of my people,

as infant and nursing child faint
in the squares of the city.
12 Their mothers[q] they keep asking,
"Where is bread, where is wine?"
while swooning like men struck down
in the town's open places,
while their breath ebbs away
in their mothers' laps.
13 What witness[r] can I offer you? What likeness find for you,
daughter Jerusalem?
What match can I set beside you, to console you,
maiden daughter Zion?
For wide as the ocean is your shattering;
who could mend you?
14 Your prophets'[s] visions for you
were emptiness and plaster;[t]
they did not lay bare your guilt
so as to reverse your captivity,
but the oracles they saw for you
were empty and led you astray.
15 They clap[u] their hands at you,
all who pass along the way;
they hiss and wag their heads
at daughter Jerusalem:
"Is this the city that was called
the perfection of beauty, the joy of all the earth?"
16 All your enemies[w] have opened[v]
their mouths wide at you;
they whistle and grind their teeth;
they cry, "We have devoured her!
This is the day we waited for;
we have lived to see it!"
17 Yahweh[x] has carried out his plan;
he has accomplished the decree
he ordained long ago;

he has demolished without mercy;
he has let the enemy gloat over you
and raised your adversaries' strength.
18 Their heart[y] cried out to the Lord.[z]
O wall of daughter Zion,
let tears run down like a torrent
day and night!
Give yourself no respite;
let not the pupil of your eye be still!
19 Arise,[aa] cry out in the night,
at the beginning of the watches![ab]
Pour out your heart like water
before the face of the Lord!
Lift up your hands to him
for the lives of your little ones,
who faint for hunger
at the head of every street.[ac]
20 "Look,[ad] Yahweh, and notice
who it is you have treated like this:
should women devour their own fruit,
infants they have nursed?
Should priest and prophet be murdered
in the Lord's holy place?
21 They lie[ae] on the ground in the streets,
young and old;
my young women and my young men
have fallen by the sword;
you have slain them in the day of your anger;
you have slaughtered without pity.
22 You summoned,[af] as to a day of appointed feast,
my terrors from all around;
and on the day of Yahweh's anger
none escaped or survived;
those whom I cherished and reared
my enemy has destroyed."

Notes

- a (2:1) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter aleph (א) (the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet).
- b (2:1) Or "has treated with contempt"; the Hebrew verb is rare.
- c (2:1) That is, the ark or the temple (compare 1 Chronicles 28:2; Psalm 132:7).
- d (2:2) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter beth (ב).
- e (2:3) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter gimel (ג).
- f (2:4) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter daleth (ד).
- g (2:5) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter he (ה).
- h (2:5) Hebrew taʾaniyyah waʾaniyyah, a sound play.
- i (2:6) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter vav (ו).
- j (2:7) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter zayin (ז).
- k (2:8) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter heth (ח).
- l (2:9) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter teth (ט).
- m (2:9) Hebrew torah.
- n (2:10) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter yod (י).
- o (2:11) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter kaph (כ).
- p (2:11) The liver was regarded as a seat of the emotions.
- q (2:12) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter lamed (ל).
- r (2:13) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter mem (מ).
- s (2:14) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter nun (נ).
- t (2:14) Hebrew tafel, "whitewash," that which covers over (compare Ezekiel 13:10).
- u (2:15) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter samekh (ס).
- v (2:16) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter peh (פ).
- w (2:16) In the Hebrew this stanza begins with peh and the next with ayin, reversing the order of chapter 1; the Septuagint's letter headings follow ayin–peh, though the verses stand in the Hebrew order (Brenton). The same reversal occurs in chapters 3 and 4.
- x (2:17) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter ayin (ע).
- y (2:18) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tsade (צ).
- z (2:18) The Hebrew is difficult; some emend to "Cry out from the heart."
- aa (2:19) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter qoph (ק).
- ab (2:19) The Septuagint reads "Arise, rejoice in the night" (Brenton).
- ac (2:19) This stanza has four lines in the Hebrew.
- ad (2:20) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter resh (ר).
- ae (2:21) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter shin (ש).
- af (2:22) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tav (ת).

Chapter 3

1 I[a]—a man who has looked on misery beneath the staff of his fury.[b] 2
Me he has driven off and made to walk in darkness and not light. 3 Yes,

at me alone he swings his hand, over and over, the whole day long. 4 He[c] has worn away my flesh and my skin; he has broken my bones. 5 He has built siege works against me and ringed me with bitterness and hardship.[d] 6 In dark places he has made me dwell, like those long dead. 7 He has walled[e] me in, and I cannot get out; he has made my chains heavy. 8 Even when I cry and call for help, he shuts out my prayer. 9 He has walled up my ways with hewn stone; my paths he has made crooked. 10 A bear[f] lying in wait he is to me, a lion in hiding. 11 My ways he has turned aside; he has torn me to pieces; he has made me desolate. 12 He bent his bow and set me as a target for the arrow. 13 He has driven[g] into my kidneys the shafts of his quiver.[h] 14 I have become a laughingstock to all my people,[i] their taunt song all the day. 15 He has filled me with bitter herbs; he has sated me with wormwood. 16 He has made[j] my teeth crunch on grit; in the ashes he has pressed me down. 17 My soul is cast off from peace; I have forgotten what good is. 18 So I said, "Gone is my endurance, and my hope from Yahweh." 19 Remember[k] my affliction and my wandering, the wormwood and the poison! 20 My soul remembers it well and is bowed down within me.[l] 21 Yet this I bring back to my heart; for this reason I wait in hope: 22 The steadfast love[m] of Yahweh never ceases;[n] his mercies do not come to an end; 23 they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness. 24 "Yahweh is my portion," says my soul; "therefore I will hope in him." 25 Good[o] is Yahweh to those who wait for him, to the soul who seeks him. 26 Good it is that one should wait in silence for the salvation of Yahweh. 27 Good it is for a man that he bear the yoke in his youth. 28 Let him sit[p] alone and keep silent, when He has laid it on him; 29 let him put his mouth in the dust—perhaps there may be hope;[q] 30 let him give his cheek to the one who strikes, and be filled with reproach. 31 For[r] the Lord will not cast off forever; 32 though he causes sorrow, he shows mercy, so great is his steadfast love; 33 for not willingly does he humble or sadden human beings. 34 To crush[s] underfoot all the prisoners of the earth, 35 to deny a man justice before the face of the Most High, 36 to subvert a person in his lawsuit—does the Lord not see?[t]

37 Who[u] can speak a thing into being, if the Lord did not decree it?
38 Is it not from the mouth of the Most High that both evil and good
go forth? 39 What grievance has a living mortal—any man—over the
penalty for his sins? 40 Let us search[v] and examine our ways and
return to Yahweh! 41 Let us lift up our hearts with our hands to God in
heaven: 42 "It is we who sinned and defied you; and you—you did not
pardon. 43 You have wrapped[w] yourself in anger and pursued us; you
have slain without pity; 44 you have wrapped yourself with a cloud, so
that no prayer can pass through; 45 you have made us offscouring and
refuse in the midst of the peoples. 46 They have opened[x] their mouths
against us, all our enemies;[y] 47 panic and pitfall have come upon us,
devastation and destruction;[z] 48 streams of water pour from my eye
over the ruin of my people's daughter. 49 My eye[aa] flows on and does
not cease, without respite, 50 until Yahweh looks down and sees from
heaven; 51 my eye torments my soul because of all the daughters of
my city.
52 Hunted[ab] me like a bird have my enemies without cause; 53 they
silenced my life in the pit and cast stones on me; 54 waters flowed
over my head; I said, "I am cut off." 55 I called[ac] on your name, O
Yahweh, from the depths of the pit; 56 you heard my plea: "Do not shut
your ear to my cry for help!"[ad] 57 You drew near on the day I called
to you; you said, "Do not be afraid!" 58 You have pleaded,[ae] O Lord,
the causes of my soul; you have redeemed my life. 59 You have seen,
O Yahweh, the wrong done to me; judge my case! 60 You have seen
all their vengeance, all their schemes against me. 61 You have heard[af]
their taunts, O Yahweh, all their schemes against me, 62 the lips of
my assailants and their muttering against me all the day. 63 See their
sitting and their rising: I am their taunt song. 64 You will repay[ag] them,
O Yahweh, according to the work of their hands. 65 Hardness of heart
you will hand them; on them be your curse![ah] 66 You will pursue them
in anger and destroy them from under the heavens of Yahweh."

Notes

- a (3:1) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter aleph (א).
- b (3:1) The speaker is an individual sufferer (Hebrew geber, "strong man"), who at times speaks for the whole people (verses 40–47).

- c (3:4) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter beth (ב).
- d (3:5) Hebrew ro'sh utela'ah, "poison and toil"; the Septuagint reads "and compassed my head, and brought travail upon me" (Brenton).
- e (3:7) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter gimel (ג).
- f (3:10) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter daleth (ד).
- g (3:13) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter he (ה).
- h (3:13) Hebrew "the sons of his quiver."
- i (3:14) So most Hebrew manuscripts; some manuscripts and the Syriac read "all peoples."
- j (3:16) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter vav (ו).
- k (3:19) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter zayin (ז).
- l (3:20) So the Hebrew consonants (Kethib); the Qere reads "and bows down." Some rabbinic lists of scribal corrections are reported to include it, as originally "your soul," spoken of God.
- m (3:22) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter heth (ח).
- n (3:22) So the Targum and Syriac, reading tammu; the Hebrew reads "The steadfast love of Yahweh, for we are not consumed" (tamnu). Brenton gives verses 22–24 as a supplement numbered 21a–c ("he has not failed me"); they are reported to be lacking in some major Greek manuscripts.
- o (3:25) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter teth (ט).
- p (3:28) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter yod (י).
- q (3:29) Verse 29 is absent from Brenton's Septuagint.
- r (3:31) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter kaph (כ).
- s (3:34) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter lamed (ל).
- t (3:36) Or "the Lord does not approve."
- u (3:37) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter mem (מ).
- v (3:40) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter nun (נ).
- w (3:43) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter samekh (ס).
- x (3:46) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter peh (פ).
- y (3:46) The peh stanza (verses 46–48) comes before the ayin stanza (verses 49–51), as in chapters 2 and 4.
- z (3:47) Hebrew paḥad wapaḥath … hashshe'th wehashshaver, a sound play.
- aa (3:49) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter ayin (ע).
- ab (3:52) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tsade (צ).
- ac (3:55) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter qoph (ק).
- ad (3:56) Or "to my sigh, to my cry." The Hebrew lerawḥathi, "for my relief," is uncertain.
- ae (3:58) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter resh (ר).
- af (3:61) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter shin (ש).
- ag (3:64) Each line of this stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tav (ת).
- ah (3:65) Hebrew meginnath lev, perhaps "a covering of heart" or "anguish of heart."

Chapter 4

1 How[a] the gold has grown dim,
the finest gold changed!
The holy stones lie scattered
at the head of every street.
2 Zion's[b] treasured sons,
worth their weight in pure gold—
ah, now counted as clay jugs,
things a potter's hands turn out!
3 Even jackals[c] bare the breast
and suckle their young;
but the daughter of my people has turned cruel,
like the ostriches in the wilderness.[d]
4 The tongue[e] of the nursing infant cleaves
to the roof of its mouth for thirst;
little children beg for bread,
but no one breaks it for them.
5 Those who ate[f] dainties
are desolate in the streets;
those reared in scarlet
embrace dunghills.
6 For greater[g] was the iniquity of the daughter of my people
than the sin of Sodom,[h]
which was overthrown in a moment,
with no hands laid upon her.
7 Her princes[i] were brighter than snow,[j]
whiter than milk;
their bodies were ruddier than coral,
their form like lapis lazuli.
8 Blacker[k] than charcoal their faces have grown;
in the lanes no one knows them;
their hide clings shrunken to their frame,
withered like a stick.
9 Better off[l] were those slain by the sword
than those slain by hunger,

who pine away, pierced,
for lack of the fruits of the field.
10 The hands[m] of compassionate women
have boiled their own children;
they became their food
in the ruin of the daughter of my people.
11 Yahweh[n] has used up his rage;
he has unleashed his fierce anger;
he lit a fire in Zion
that has devoured her foundations.
12 Never[o] would earth's kings have credited it,
nor any who live in the world,
that adversary or assailant would march
through Jerusalem's gates.
13 It was[p] for the sins of her prophets,
the iniquities of her priests,
who shed in her midst
the blood of the righteous.
14 They staggered[q] through the streets like the blind,
soaked in so much blood
that no one dared touch
their clothing.
15 "Off with you! Defiled!"[r] they shouted at them;
"Off, off! Keep your hands away!"
So they ran and roamed about;
among the peoples men said,
"Here they may lodge no more."
16 Yahweh's own presence[s] has dispersed them;[t]
no more will he look upon them;
for priests there was no respect,
for elders no kindness.
17 Still[u] our eyes failed,
looking in vain for help;
from our watchtower we watched
for a nation that could not save.[v]

18 Our footsteps[w] they stalked,
barring us from walking in our own plazas;
near was our finish, full our days;
yes, our finish had arrived.
19 Swifter[x] were our pursuers
than the eagles of the heavens;
on the mountains they chased us;
in the wilderness they lay in wait for us.
20 The breath[y] of our nostrils, the anointed of Yahweh,[z]
was caught in their pits,
he of whom we said, “Under his shadow
we shall live among the nations.”
21 Be joyful[aa] and celebrate, daughter of Edom,
you who live in the land of Uz![ab]
The cup will come around to you too;
you will get drunk and expose your nakedness.
22 Your guilt,[ac] daughter of Zion, has been paid in full;
he will not keep you in exile any longer;
but your guilt, daughter of Edom, he will punish;
he will lay bare your sins.

Notes

- a (4:1) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter aleph (א) (the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet).
- b (4:2) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter beth (ב).
- c (4:3) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter gimel (ג).
- d (4:3) So the Qere; the Kethib reads a variant spelling. The Septuagint reads “serpents” for “jackals” (Brenton).
- e (4:4) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter daleth (ד).
- f (4:5) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter he (ה).
- g (4:6) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter vav (ו).
- h (4:6) Or “the punishment … than the punishment of Sodom”; Hebrew ʿawon and ḥatta’th can mean both offense and its penalty. Compare Genesis 19.
- i (4:7) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter zayin (ז).
- j (4:7) Or “her consecrated ones,” Hebrew nezireha (compare Numbers 6); the Septuagint reads “Her Nazarites” (Brenton).
- k (4:8) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter heth (ח).
- l (4:9) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter teth (ט).

- m (4:10) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter yod (י).
- n (4:11) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter kaph (כ).
- o (4:12) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter lamed (ל).
- p (4:13) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter mem (מ).
- q (4:14) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter nun (נ).
- r (4:15) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter samekh (ס).
- s (4:16) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter peh (פ).
- t (4:16) Here again peh precedes ayin; the Septuagint's headings read Ain, then Phe, though its verses follow the Hebrew order (Brenton).
- u (4:17) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter ayin (ע).
- v (4:17) Probably Egypt (compare Jeremiah 37:5–10).
- w (4:18) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tsade (צ).
- x (4:19) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter qoph (ק).
- y (4:20) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter resh (ר).
- z (4:20) That is, King Zedekiah (compare Jeremiah 39:4–7; 52:7–11). The Septuagint reads "our anointed Lord" (Brenton).
- aa (4:21) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter shin (ש).
- ab (4:21) Uz, a region associated with Edom (compare Job 1:1; Jeremiah 25:20). The Septuagint lacks "of Uz" (Brenton).
- ac (4:22) This stanza begins with the Hebrew letter tav (ת).

Chapter 5

1 Remember, Yahweh, what has happened to us;[a]
look and see how we are disgraced!
2 Our inheritance has been turned over to strangers,
our houses to foreigners.
3 Orphans we are, without a father;
our mothers are as women bereaved.
4 Our own water we drink for silver;
our wood comes to us for a price.
5 With a yoke on our necks[b] we are driven hard;
we are weary; no rest is given us.
6 To Egypt we have held out the hand,
and to Assyria, to get enough bread.
7 It was our fathers who sinned—they are gone—
yet the load of their guilt is ours to carry.
8 Slaves rule over us;
there is none to tear us from their hand.

9 At the peril of our lives we get our bread,
because of the sword in the wilderness.
10 Our skin is hot as an oven
from the burning heat of famine.
11 Women in Zion are ravished,
young women in the towns of Judah.
12 By their hands officials are strung up;
elders' faces get no regard.
13 Young men carry the millstone,[c]
and boys stagger under loads of wood.
14 Gone from the gate are the old men,
gone from their songs the youths.
15 Our hearts' gladness is at an end;
our dancing is changed to grief.
16 The crown has fallen from our head;
woe to us, for we have sinned!
17 Because of this our hearts are faint;
because of all this our eyes are clouded,
18 for Mount Zion, which lies desolate;
foxes[d] prowl over it.
19 Yet you, Yahweh, sit enthroned for all time;
your seat of rule stands age after age.
20 Why will you forget us forever,
forsake us for so many days?
21 Turn us back to yourself, O Yahweh, and we shall turn;
renew our days as of old—
22 —or have you cast us off completely,
raging against us beyond measure?[e]

Notes

- a (5:1) Chapter 5 is not an acrostic, but it has twenty-two verses, matching the letters of the alphabet, and its lines are mostly balanced couplets rather than the lament meter of chapters 1–4. Some Latin manuscripts are reported to title it "A Prayer of Jeremiah the Prophet."
- b (5:5) So a slight emendation; the Hebrew reads "Upon our necks we are pursued."

- c (5:13) The Septuagint reads “The chosen men lifted up the voice in weeping” (Brenton).
- d (5:18) Or “jackals.”
- e (5:22) The Hebrew of verse 22 (ki ʾim) is difficult; it may also be read “unless you have utterly rejected us.” In synagogue reading, verse 21 is repeated after verse 22 so that the book does not end on a note of rejection. The Septuagint reads “For you have indeed rejected us” (Brenton, modernized).

Ezekiel

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the thirtieth year,[a] on the fifth day of the fourth month (in June–
July),[b] while I was among the exiles beside the Chebar canal,[c] the
heavens opened and I saw visions of God. 2 It was the fifth day of the
month, in the fifth year after King Jehoiachin was taken into exile[d]
— 3 the word of Yahweh came directly to the priest Ezekiel[e] son of
Buzi,[f] in Chaldean territory beside the Chebar canal; and the hand of
Yahweh was upon him there.
4 As I watched, a storm wind was sweeping in from the north: an im-
mense cloud with fire flashing back and forth, a radiance surrounding
it, and at its center something that gleamed like glowing metal[g] in the
heart of the fire. 5 Within it was the form of four living creatures, and
this was how they looked: they had a human shape, 6 but each one had
four faces, and each had four wings. 7 Their legs were straight, and
their feet were shaped like a calf's hoof; they glittered like burnished
bronze. 8 Human hands were under their wings on all four sides. And
the faces and wings of the four of them looked like this: 9 their wings
touched one another. They did not turn as they moved; each went
straight ahead. 10 The form of their faces was this: each of the four
had a human face in front, a lion's face on the right, an ox's face on
the left, and an eagle's face as well. 11 Those were their faces. Their
wings were stretched upward; two wings of each creature touched
the wings of the creature beside it, and two wings covered its body.
12 Each moved directly forward. Where the spirit[h] was to go, there
they went; they never turned in their going. 13 As for the likeness of
the living creatures, their appearance was like burning coals of fire,
like torches. Fire moved to and fro among the creatures; the fire was
bright, and lightning shot out of it. 14 And the living creatures darted
back and forth like flashes of lightning.[i]

15 While I gazed at the living creatures, I noticed one wheel on the
ground next to each creature, by all four of them. 16 The wheels and
their construction looked like the sparkle of chrysolite;[j] all four had
the same form, and they were built as though one wheel were set
inside another. 17 In moving they went toward any one of their four
sides and did not swing around while going. 18 Their rims were tall
and fearsome, and the rims of all four were covered with eyes all
around. 19 When the living creatures moved, the wheels moved beside
them; when the creatures rose from the ground, the wheels rose
too. 20 Where the spirit was to go, there they went, and the wheels
lifted up together with them, because the spirit of the living creature[k]
was in the wheels. 21 Whenever the creatures went, the wheels went;
whenever they halted, the wheels halted; and whenever they were
lifted off the ground, the wheels were lifted alongside them, because
the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels.
22 Over the heads of the living creatures was the likeness of a vault,[l]
gleaming like awe-inspiring crystal, stretched out above their heads. 23
Beneath the vault their wings were stretched straight out, one toward
another; each creature also had two wings covering its body on one
side and two on the other. 24 When they moved, I heard the sound of
their wings like the roar of vast waters, like the voice of Shaddai,[m]
a tumult like the noise of an army. When they stood still, they let
their wings drop. 25 Then a voice came from above the vault over their
heads; whenever they stood still, they lowered their wings.
26 Above the vault that was over their heads there was the likeness
of a throne, like lapis lazuli in appearance,[n] and seated above on that
likeness of a throne was a likeness with a human appearance. 27 From
what looked like his waist upward I saw something like gleaming
metal, with what seemed to be fire enclosing it all around; and from
what looked like his waist downward I saw what seemed to be fire,
with brightness surrounding him. 28 Like the look of the rainbow that
shows in the clouds on a rainy day, such was the radiance all around
him. That was how the likeness of the glory of Yahweh appeared.
As soon as I saw it, I threw myself on my face, and I heard a voice
speaking.

Notes

- a (1:1) The reference point of "the thirtieth year" is uncertain. It may be Ezekiel's age (the age at which priests began service, Num 4:3), or it may be counted from some other event, such as Josiah's reform.
- b (1:1) Hebrew: "in the fourth month, on the fifth of the month." Months are counted from the spring new year; the fourth month (later called Tammuz) fell in June–July. On the date given in v. 2 this was 593 BC.
- c (1:1) Or "river." The Chebar was a canal of the Euphrates near Nippur in Babylonia.
- d (1:2) That is, 593 BC. Jehoiachin was deported to Babylon in 597 BC (2 Kgs 24:10–15); Ezekiel counts his dates from this exile.
- e (1:3) Ezekiel means "God strengthens" or "may God strengthen." The Greek has "Jezekiel."
- f (1:3) Buzi may mean "my contempt"; the meaning is uncertain.
- g (1:4) Hebrew hashmal, a rare word of uncertain meaning; the Greek has "amber" (electrum). Also in v. 27.
- h (1:12) Or "wind"; also in v. 20.
- i (1:14) Verse 14 is not found in the Greek (Septuagint).
- j (1:16) Hebrew tarshish, a precious stone of uncertain identity, perhaps beryl or topaz.
- k (1:20) Or "the spirit of life"; "living creature" here is singular, perhaps referring to the creatures as a whole.
- l (1:22) Or "platform," "expanse"; the same word as in Gen 1:6.
- m (1:24) Shaddai is a divine name, traditionally "the Almighty"; its original meaning is uncertain. The Greek lacks "like the voice of Shaddai."
- n (1:26) Hebrew sappir, probably lapis lazuli rather than the modern sapphire.

Chapter 2

1 He said to me, "Son of man,[a] get to your feet, and I will speak to you."
2 While he was speaking with me, the Spirit came into me and stood
me upright, and I listened to the one who addressed me. 3 He said to
me, "Son of man, I am sending you to the people of Israel, to rebellious
nations that have rebelled against me. They and their ancestors have
revolted against me to this very day. 4 The descendants are hard-faced
and stubborn-hearted. I am sending you to them, and you will say to
them, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says.' 5 Whether they hear or
hold back—since they are a house of rebels—they will come to know
that a prophet has lived among them. 6 As for you, son of man, do not
be afraid of them or of their words. Even though briars and thorns

surround you and you sit among scorpions, do not fear their words
or be shaken by their looks, for they are a rebellious house. 7 You are
to speak my words to them whether they listen or refuse, for they are
rebellious.
8 "But you, son of man, listen to what I am telling you. Do not be
rebellious like that rebellious house. Open your mouth and eat what
I am giving you." 9 Then I looked, and a hand was stretched out to me,
and in it was a written scroll. 10 He spread it open in front of me; it was
inscribed inside and out, and on it were written laments, mourning,
and woe.

Notes

- a (2:1) Hebrew ben adam, "son of a human being," an idiom meaning "human one" or "mortal." It stresses the prophet's frailty before God and is used about ninety times in Ezekiel. The traditional rendering is kept because of the related expression in Dan 7:13 and Jesus' use of "the Son of Man" in the Gospels.

Chapter 3

1 He said to me, "Son of man, eat what is in front of you. Eat this scroll,
then go and speak to the house of Israel." 2 So I opened my mouth, and
he fed me the scroll. 3 He said to me, "Son of man, let your stomach
take in this scroll I give you, and fill your insides with it." So I ate, and
in my mouth it tasted sweet as honey.
4 Then he said to me, "Son of man, go now to the house of Israel
and speak my words to them. 5 It is not to a nation of strange lips
and heavy tongue that you are sent, but to the house of Israel— 6 not
to many peoples of unintelligible speech and hard language whose
words you could not understand. Surely, if I had sent you to them,
they would listen to you. 7 But the Israelites will not be willing to
hear you, since they are not willing to hear me; the whole nation is
hard-headed and hard-hearted. 8 Look, I am making your face firm to
match their faces, and your brow firm to match their brows. 9 I have
made your forehead like a diamond,[a] harder than flint. Do not fear
them or be dismayed by their looks, for they are a rebellious house."
10 He said to me, "Son of man, take to heart all my words that I speak
to you, and listen closely. 11 Go now to the exiles, to your own people.

Speak to them and tell them, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says,' whether they listen or refuse."
12 Then the Spirit raised me up, and I heard behind me the sound of a great earthquake: "May the glory of Yahweh be praised from where he dwells!"[b] 13 What I heard was the wings of the living creatures beating against each other and the rumbling of the wheels next to them, a great roaring noise. 14 The Spirit lifted me and took me away, and I went in bitterness, in the heat of my spirit, with the hand of Yahweh pressing hard on me. 15 I came to the exiles at Tel-abib,[c] the ones living beside the Chebar canal. I sat where they were sitting, and I remained there among them seven days, overwhelmed.
16 At the end of seven days the word of Yahweh came to me: 17 "Son of man, I have set you as a lookout for Israel's house. Whenever a word comes from my mouth, you are to warn them for me. 18 If I tell a wicked man, 'You will surely die,' and you give him no warning—if you say nothing to warn him away from his wicked course so as to save his life—that wicked man will die in his guilt, but I will require his blood from your hand. 19 But if you do warn the wicked, and he does not turn back from his wickedness and his evil course, he will die in his guilt, but you will have rescued your own life. 20 Again, when a righteous person turns from his righteousness and does wrong, and I put a stumbling block before him, he will die. Because you did not warn him, he will die for his sin; the righteous deeds he did will not be remembered, but I will hold you responsible for his blood. 21 But if you do warn the righteous person to avoid sin and he avoids it, he will certainly live, because he heeded the warning, and you will have rescued yourself."
22 There the hand of Yahweh came upon me, and he said to me, "Get up and go out to the valley,[d] and there I will speak with you." 23 So I rose and went out into the valley, and the glory of Yahweh was standing there, just like the glory I had seen beside the Chebar canal; and I threw myself on my face. 24 Then the Spirit entered me and set me on my feet. He spoke with me and said, "Go, shut yourself inside your house. 25 As for you, son of man, ropes will be put on you, and you will be bound with them so that you cannot go out among them. 26

I will make your tongue stick to the roof of your mouth so that you will be mute and unable to rebuke them, for they are a rebellious house. 27 But when I speak with you, I will open your mouth, and you will say to them, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says.' Whoever will listen, let him listen; whoever will refuse, let him refuse; for they are a rebellious house."

Notes

- a (3:9) Hebrew shamir, a very hard stone, perhaps emery or diamond.
- b (3:12) With a slight change of one letter, the Hebrew could read "as the glory of Yahweh rose from its place," which many scholars prefer.
- c (3:15) In Hebrew Tel-abib suggests "mound of ripe grain"; it is probably a Hebrew form of a Babylonian name meaning "mound of the flood," that is, an ancient ruin mound.
- d (3:22) Or "plain."

Chapter 4

1 "Now you, son of man, take a clay brick, set it before you, and engrave on it a city, Jerusalem. 2 Lay siege to it: build siege works against it, heap up a ramp against it, set up camps against it, and position battering rams against it all around. 3 Next take an iron baking plate and stand it up as a wall of iron separating you from the city. Set your face against it, so that it is under siege and you are its besieger. This will be a sign to the house of Israel.

4 "Next, lie down on your left side and place on it the guilt of the house of Israel. As many days as you lie on that side, you will carry their guilt. 5 I have assigned you a number of days matching the years of their guilt: three hundred ninety days.[a] So you will bear the guilt of the house of Israel. 6 When you have completed these, lie down a second time, on your right side, and bear the guilt of the house of Judah forty days—a day for each year; I have assigned it to you. 7 Fix your gaze on besieged Jerusalem, bare your arm, and prophesy against the city. 8 Look, I am tying you with cords, and you will not roll from one side to the other until you finish the days of your siege. 9 "Now take wheat, barley, beans, lentils, millet, and spelt; put them together in a single jar and bake your bread from them. All the days you are lying on your side—three hundred ninety days—you will eat

it. 10 The food you eat will be weighed out: about eight ounces[b] a day.
You will eat it at set times. 11 You will also drink water by measure,
about two-thirds of a quart[c] a day; drink it at set times. 12 Eat it as
you would a barley cake, baking it in their sight over human dung."
13 Yahweh said, "This is how the Israelites will eat their food, defiled,
among the nations where I am about to banish them." 14 Then I said,
"Ah, Lord Yahweh! I have never been made unclean. Since boyhood
I have not eaten the flesh of an animal that died naturally or was
mauled, and no foul meat has passed my lips." 15 He answered me,
"All right. I will allow you cow manure in place of human excrement,
and you may bake your bread on it." 16 Then he said to me, "Son of
man, I am going to break the food supply in Jerusalem. They will eat
their food by weight, anxiously, and drink their water by measure, in
horror, 17 so that they will lack bread and water, stare at one another
in horror, and waste away in their guilt.

Notes

- a (4:5) The Greek has "one hundred ninety days" here and in v. 9, and "one hundred fifty days" in v. 4.
- b (4:10) Hebrew: "twenty shekels" (about 230 grams).
- c (4:11) Hebrew: "a sixth of a hin" (about 0.6 liter).

Chapter 5

1 "Now you, son of man, take a sharp sword and use it like a barber's
razor, running it over your head and beard. Then take balances and
divide up the hair you cut off. 2 A third you are to burn with fire
in the middle of the city when the siege days are over. A third you
are to take and cut up with the sword around the city. A third you
are to scatter to the wind, and I will draw a sword to pursue them. 3
Take from them a few strands and tuck them into the folds of your
garment. 4 Then take some more of them, cast them into the fire, and
let them burn. Out of that fire a blaze will go forth against the whole
house of Israel.
5 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says: This is Jerusalem. I placed her
at the center of the nations, with countries all around her. 6 She has
defied my laws with more evil than the other nations have, and my
decrees more than the lands around her; she has rejected my laws

and has refused to follow my decrees. 7 "Therefore this is what the
Lord Yahweh says: Because you have been more turbulent than the
nations around you, have not walked in my statutes or carried out my
judgments, and have not even acted by the standards of the nations
around you,[a] 8 therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: I, I myself,
am against you. I will carry out judgments in your midst in the sight
of the nations. 9 For all your abominations I will deal with you in a
way I have not dealt before and in a way I will never deal again. 10 So in
your midst fathers will eat their sons, and sons will eat their fathers.
I will carry out punishments against you, and I will scatter whatever
is left of you in every direction. 11 Therefore, as I live, declares the
Lord Yahweh, because you have defiled my sanctuary with all your
detestable things and all your abominations, I myself will withdraw;[b]
my eye will not spare, and I will have no pity. 12 A third of your people
will die by plague or perish of hunger inside your walls; a third will be
cut down by the sword outside them; and the last third I will scatter
in all directions, drawing a sword to pursue them.
13 "Then my anger will be spent, and I will satisfy my fury on them
and be appeased. And they will know that I, Yahweh, have spoken in
my zeal, when I have spent my fury on them. 14 I will turn you into
a wasteland and an object of scorn among the surrounding nations,
before the eyes of everyone who travels past. 15 You will become a
disgrace and a thing of mockery, an object lesson and a horror to
the nations about you, when I bring judgments upon you with anger,
fury, and furious punishments. I, Yahweh, have spoken. 16 When I
shoot at them the deadly arrows of famine, arrows meant to destroy,
which I will send to destroy you, I will increase the famine on you
and break your supply of bread. 17 I will send against you famine and
savage beasts that will rob you of your children. Pestilence and blood
will pass through your streets, and I will bring a sword down on you.
I, Yahweh, have spoken."

Notes

- a (5:7) Some ancient witnesses lack "not," reading "but have acted by the standards of the nations" (compare 11:12).
- b (5:11) Or "I will cut you down"; the Hebrew verb is uncertain.

Chapter 6

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 “Son of man, set your face toward
the mountains of Israel and prophesy against them. 3 Say, ‘Mountains
of Israel, hear the word of the Lord Yahweh! This is what the Lord
Yahweh says to the mountains and the hills, to the ravines and the
valleys: Look, I will bring a sword against you, and I will destroy
your high places.[a] 4 Your altars will be laid waste and your incense
stands broken; and the slain among you I will throw down before
your idols.[b] 5 I will lay the corpses of the people of Israel before their
idols and scatter your bones around your altars. 6 In all the places
where you live, your cities will lie in ruins and your high places will
be devastated, so that your altars are broken down and left in ruins,
your idols are shattered and finished, your incense altars are chopped
down, and everything you made is erased. 7 The slain will fall among
you, and you will know that I am Yahweh.
8 “‘Yet I will leave a remnant: some of you will escape the sword
among the nations when you are scattered through the countries. 9
Then those of you who escape will remember me among the nations
where they are held captive—how I was crushed by their unfaithful
hearts that turned away from me, and by their eyes that went lusting
after their idols. They will loathe themselves for the evils they have
done, for all their abominations. 10 And they will know that I am
Yahweh; I did not threaten in vain to bring this disaster on them.’
11 “This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Strike your hands together,
stamp your foot, and cry out, ‘How terrible!’ because of all the vile
practices of the house of Israel, for they will die by the sword, by
hunger and by disease. 12 Whoever is far away will die of plague;
whoever is near will fall by the sword; and whoever remains and is
spared will die of famine. So I will spend my fury on them. 13 And you
will know that I am Yahweh when their slain lie among their idols
around their altars, on every high hill, on all the mountaintops, under
every green tree and every leafy oak—wherever they offered soothing
aromas to all their idols. 14 I will stretch out my hand against them
and make the land a desolate waste, from the wilderness to Diblah,[c]
in all their settlements. Then they will know that I am Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (6:3) Local hilltop shrines used for worship, often of other gods.
- b (6:4) Hebrew gillulim, a contemptuous word for idols, perhaps "dung-gods"; it occurs some forty times in Ezekiel.
- c (6:14) The location of Diblah is unknown. Many scholars read Riblah, a town in Syria, since the Hebrew letters d and r look very similar.

Chapter 7

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "You, son of man—this is what the
Lord Yahweh says to the land of Israel:[a] An end! The end has come
upon the four corners of the land. 3 The end is here for you now. I will
let loose my anger on you, I will judge you by how you have lived,
and I will repay you for all your vile practices. 4 My eye will not spare
you, and I will have no pity. I will repay you for your ways, and your
abominations will remain in your midst. Then you will know that I
am Yahweh.
5 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Disaster! A unique disaster—
look, it is coming! 6 An end has come; the end has come. It has roused
itself against you—look, it is coming! 7 Your doom[b] has come to you,
inhabitant of the land. The time has come; the day is near—a day of
panic, not of joyful shouting on the mountains. 8 Soon I will pour my
wrath upon you; I will bring my anger to its full against you. I will
judge you according to your ways and hold all your abominations
against you. 9 My eye will not spare, and I will have no pity. I will
repay you for your ways, and your abominations will remain in your
midst. Then you will know that it is I, Yahweh, who strike.
10 "Look, the day! Look, it is coming! Your doom has gone out; the rod
has blossomed, arrogance has budded. 11 Violence has grown into a
rod of wickedness. None of them will be left—none of their crowd,
none of their wealth, nothing of distinction among them.[c] 12 The time
has come; the day has arrived. Let the buyer not rejoice or the seller
mourn, for wrath is upon all its throng. 13 The seller will not return
to what was sold as long as both of them live, for the vision concerns
all its throng; it will not be revoked. Because of their guilt, not one of
them will preserve his life.[d]

14 “The trumpet has sounded and everything is prepared, yet nobody
marches out to fight, because my fury is against their whole crowd. 15
The sword is outside; plague and famine are inside. Whoever is in the
field will die by the sword, and whoever is in the city will be devoured
by famine and plague. 16 Even if their survivors escape, they will be
on the mountains like doves of the valleys, all of them moaning, each
for his guilt. 17 Every hand will hang limp, and every knee will run
with water.[e] 18 They will put on sackcloth, and horror will cover them.
Shame will be on every face and baldness on every head. 19 They will
throw their silver into the streets, and their gold will become a thing
unclean. Neither their silver nor their gold will be able to save them
on the day of Yahweh’s fury. They will not fill their appetites or their
bellies with it, for it was the stumbling block of their guilt. 20 Their
beautiful ornaments they turned to pride, and from them they made
the images of their abominations and their detestable things. That is
why I am making it unclean to them. 21 I will hand it over as loot to
foreigners and as spoil to the earth’s most wicked people, and they
will defile it. 22 I will avert my face from them as they profane my
treasured place. Robbers will come into it and profane it.
23 “Forge a chain,[f] for the land is full of bloody crimes and the city is
full of violence. 24 I will bring in the most evil of the nations, and they
will seize their houses. I will end the pride of the mighty, and their
sanctuaries will be profaned. 25 Anguish is coming! They will look for
peace, and there will be no peace. 26 Calamity will follow calamity and
rumor will follow rumor. They will seek a vision from a prophet, but
instruction will perish from the priest and counsel from the elders.
27 The king will mourn, and the prince will be clothed in desolation;
the hands of the common people will shake. I will treat them as their
ways deserve and judge them by their own judgments. Then they will
know that I am Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (7:2) The Greek arranges vv. 3–9 in a different order and in a shorter form.
- b (7:7) Hebrew tsephirah, a word of uncertain meaning; also in v. 10. Others render “turn” or “crown.”
- c (7:11) The Hebrew of v. 11 is obscure.

- d (7:13) The Hebrew of v. 13 is difficult; "will preserve his life" may also be rendered "will strengthen himself."
- e (7:17) That is, they will wet themselves with fear.
- f (7:23) The meaning of this phrase is uncertain; the Greek lacks it.

Chapter 8

1 In the sixth year, on the fifth day of the sixth month (in August–
September),[a] I was sitting in my house, and the elders of Judah were
seated in front of me, when the hand of the Lord Yahweh fell on me
there. 2 I looked, and there was a figure that appeared to be fire;[b] from
what looked like his waist downward he was fire, and from his waist
upward he had a dazzling glow, like gleaming metal. 3 He reached
out something shaped like a hand and grabbed me by the hair of my
head. The Spirit raised me up between earth and sky and brought me
to Jerusalem in visions from God, to the doorway of the north-facing
inner gate, where the idol that arouses jealousy stood. 4 And there
was the glory of the God of Israel, like the vision I had seen in the
valley.
5 Then he said to me, "Son of man, raise your eyes northward." So I
raised my eyes northward, and there it was: north of the gate of the
altar, at its entrance, stood this idol of jealousy. 6 He said to me, "Son
of man, do you see what they are doing? Do you see the terrible vile
practices the house of Israel carries on here, which drive me away
from my sanctuary? You will see even worse vile practices."
7 Next he led me to the doorway of the court, and as I looked I saw
a hole in the wall. 8 "Son of man," he said, "break through the wall."
I broke through the wall, and I found a door. 9 He said to me, "Go in
and see the evil abominations they are committing here." 10 I entered
and looked: engraved over the whole wall were figures of every sort
of crawling creature and detestable animal, together with all the idols
of the house of Israel. 11 In front of them stood seventy of the elders
of the house of Israel, and Jaazaniah[c] son of Shaphan[d] stood in their
midst. Every man held a censer in his hand, and a fragrant cloud of
incense was going up. 12 He said to me, "Son of man, do you see what
the elders of the house of Israel do in darkness, every one of them
in his chamber of carved images? They are saying, 'Yahweh does not

see us; Yahweh has abandoned the land.'" 13 He said to me further, "You will yet see them committing abominations greater still."
14 Then he took me to the doorway of the gate of Yahweh's house on the north side, and women were sitting there weeping for Tammuz.[e]
15 He said to me, "Have you seen this, son of man? You will see still greater abominations than these."
16 Then he brought me into the inner court of the house of Yahweh, and there at the entrance of the temple of Yahweh, between the porch and the altar, were about twenty-five men with their backs to the temple of Yahweh and their faces toward the east. They were bowing down eastward to the sun. 17 He said to me, "Have you seen this, son of man? Is it not enough for the house of Judah to commit the abominations they are committing here, that they must also fill the land with violence and provoke me again and again? Look, they are putting the branch to their nose![f] 18 Therefore I will act in fury. My eye will not spare, and I will have no pity. Though they cry in my ears with a loud voice, I will not listen to them."

Notes

- a (8:1) Hebrew: "in the sixth month, on the fifth of the month," counting from the spring new year; this was the month later called Elul, in 592 BC. The Greek has "the fifth month" (July–August).
- b (8:2) Hebrew esh, "fire"; the Greek reads ish, "a man," which many scholars prefer (compare 1:27).
- c (8:11) Jaazaniah means "Yahweh listens."
- d (8:11) Shaphan means "rock badger" (hyrax). He was probably the royal secretary under Josiah (2 Kgs 22:3), whose family supported Jeremiah.
- e (8:14) Tammuz (Sumerian Dumuzi) was a Mesopotamian god of fertility whose death was mourned each summer; the fourth month of the later Jewish calendar (June–July) is named after him.
- f (8:17) The meaning of this expression is uncertain; it apparently describes a pagan ritual gesture or an insult. Jewish tradition reads "to my nose," one of the "corrections of the scribes."

Chapter 9

1 Then he called out in my hearing with a loud voice, "Bring near those appointed to punish the city, each with his weapon of destruction in his hand." 2 Then six men came by way of the upper gate that looks

northward, each gripping his weapon of destruction. Among them was a man in linen clothing, with a scribe's writing kit at his side. They entered and stood next to the bronze altar.
3 The glory of the God of Israel rose up from the cherub[a] where it had rested and moved to the doorway of the temple. Then Yahweh called to the man who was wearing linen and had a scribe's inkwell at his waist, 4 and Yahweh told him, "Pass through the city, all through Jerusalem, and mark[b] the foreheads of the people who sigh and groan over all the abominations done within it." 5 While I listened, he said to the others, "Follow him through the city and kill. Show no mercy and spare no one. 6 Old man, youth, and maiden, little ones and women—slay them all, to utter destruction. But do not come near anyone who bears the mark. Start at my sanctuary." So they started with the elders standing in front of the temple. 7 He told them, "Make the temple unclean and fill its courtyards with corpses. Go!" So they went out and killed throughout the city. 8 While they struck the people down and I was left by myself, I threw myself facedown and cried, "Ah, Lord Yahweh! Will you wipe out the whole remnant of Israel in pouring out your fury on Jerusalem?" 9 He answered me, "The wrongdoing of Israel and Judah is enormous. The land is filled with murder, and the city is filled with injustice, because they say, 'Yahweh has forsaken the land, and Yahweh cannot see.' 10 As for me, my eye will not spare, and I will have no pity; I will bring their conduct down on their own heads." 11 Then the man in linen clothing, the writing kit at his side, brought his report: "I have done just as you ordered me."

Notes

- a (9:3) Cherubim were winged heavenly beings, often guardians of holy places (Gen 3:24); here, probably the cherubim of the ark in the Most Holy Place.
- b (9:4) Hebrew taw, the last letter of the Hebrew alphabet, which in the script of the time was written like an X or a cross.

Chapter 10

1 Then I looked, and above the vault over the heads of the cherubim there appeared something like lapis lazuli, in form like a throne. 2 He said to the man dressed in linen, "Go in among the whirling wheels[a] beneath the cherubim. Take a double handful of the fiery coals from

between the cherubim and throw them across the city." I watched him
go in. 3 The cherubim were standing on the south side of the house
when the man went in, and the cloud filled the inner court. 4 Then the
glory of Yahweh rose up from the cherub and moved to the doorway
of the temple. The cloud filled the temple, and the radiance of the
glory of Yahweh filled the courtyard. 5 The noise of the wings of the
cherubim carried all the way to the outer court, like the voice of El
Shaddai[b] speaking.
6 When he commanded the man dressed in linen, "Take fire from
among the whirling wheels, from among the cherubim," the man
went in and stood beside a wheel. 7 One of the cherubim reached out
his hand from between the cherubim to the fire that was among them,
took some, and put it into the hands of the man clothed in linen, who
took it and went out. 8 Something shaped like a human hand could be
seen beneath the wings of the cherubim.
9 I looked, and there were four wheels beside the cherubim, one wheel
beside each cherub; the wheels looked like the gleam of a chrysolite
stone. 10 As for their appearance, all four had the same form, as if one
wheel were inside another. 11 As they moved, they could travel in any
of their four directions; they did not turn as they moved, but followed
the direction the head faced, without turning. 12 Their whole bodies—
backs, hands, and wings—and the wheels too were covered with eyes
all around; the four of them had their wheels. 13 As for the wheels,
I heard them called "the whirling wheels."[c] 14 Each of them had four
faces: the first face was that of a cherub, the second was that of a man,
the third was that of a lion, and the fourth was that of an eagle.[d]
15 Then the cherubim rose up. They were the same living creatures
I had seen at the Chebar canal. 16 As the cherubim went, the wheels
went at their side; and as the cherubim lifted their wings to mount
up from the earth, the wheels too stayed with them and did not turn
away. 17 When the cherubim stood still, the wheels stood still; when
they rose, the wheels rose with them, for the spirit of the living
creature was in them.
18 Then the glory of Yahweh departed from the doorway of the temple
and halted over the cherubim. 19 As I watched, the cherubim lifted

their wings and rose up from the earth, and the wheels went out alongside them. They halted at the entry of the east gate of Yahweh's house, and above them was the glory of the God of Israel. 20 They were the same living creatures I had seen under the God of Israel at the Chebar canal; and I recognized that they were cherubim. 21 Every one had four faces and four wings, and something like human hands was under their wings. 22 Their faces looked just like the faces I had seen beside the Chebar canal. Each of them moved straight forward.

Notes

- a (10:2) Or "whirling wheels" (Hebrew galgal); also in vv. 6 and 13.
- b (10:5) El Shaddai is traditionally "God Almighty"; the original meaning of Shaddai is uncertain.
- c (10:13) Hebrew galgal, a word suggesting whirling or rolling.
- d (10:14) Verse 14 is not found in the Greek. Compare 1:10, where the face of an ox stands in place of "the face of the cherub."

Chapter 11

1 The Spirit then raised me and brought me to the east-facing gate of Yahweh's house. At the gate's entrance were twenty-five men, and I saw among them two leaders of the people, Jaazaniah son of Azzur[a] and Pelatiah[b] son of Benaiah.[c] 2 He said to me, "Son of man, these are the men who plot evil and give bad advice in this city. 3 They say, 'Is not the time near to build houses? This city is the pot, and we are the meat.'[d] 4 Therefore prophesy against them; prophesy, son of man."
5 Then the Spirit of Yahweh fell upon me, and he told me, "Say, 'This is what Yahweh says: That is what you are saying, house of Israel; I know the thoughts that rise in your mind. 6 You have multiplied your slain in this city and filled its streets with the dead. 7 Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: The bodies you have laid in its midst are the meat, and this city is the pot; but you I will bring out of it. 8 You have feared the sword, and the sword is what I will bring upon you, declares the Lord Yahweh. 9 I will drag you out of the city and deliver you into the hands of outsiders, and I will carry out my sentences against you. 10 You will fall by the sword; I will judge you at the border of Israel. Then you will know that I am Yahweh. 11 This city will not serve as your cooking pot, nor will you be the meat inside

it; at the frontier of Israel I will judge you. 12 Then you will know
that I am Yahweh, whose statutes you have not walked in and whose
judgments you have not carried out; instead, you have acted by the
standards of the nations around you.'"[e]
13 While I was prophesying, Pelatiah son of Benaiah died. Then I fell
facedown and cried out with a loud voice, "Ah, Lord Yahweh! Will
you put a complete end to the remnant of Israel?"
14 The word of Yahweh came to me: 15 "Son of man, your brothers—your
own brothers, your relatives,[f] and the whole house of Israel, all of
them—are the ones of whom the inhabitants of Jerusalem have said,
'Keep far from Yahweh; this land was given to us as our possession.'
16 "Therefore say, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Although I
removed them far away among the nations and dispersed them across
the countries, I have been a small sanctuary[g] for them in the countries
where they have gone.' 17 "Therefore say, 'The Lord Yahweh declares:
I will collect you from the nations, bring you together from the
countries where you were dispersed, and give you the land of Israel.'
18 They will come there and clear out of it all its vile things and all its
abominations. 19 I will give them a single heart[h] and place a new spirit
inside them. I will remove the stony heart from their bodies and give
them a heart of flesh, 20 so that they may walk in my statutes, keep
my judgments, and carry them out. Then they will be my people, and
I will be their God. 21 But those whose hearts follow the desire of their
vile things and abominations—I will repay their deeds on their own
heads, declares the Lord Yahweh."
22 Then the cherubim lifted their wings, with the wheels beside them,
and the glory of the God of Israel was above them. 23 The glory of
Yahweh went up from the midst of the city and stopped over the
mountain east of the city.[i] 24 The Spirit lifted me up and brought me
in the vision, by the Spirit of God, to the exiles in Chaldea. Then the
vision I had seen left me, 25 and I told the exiles everything Yahweh
had shown me.

Notes

• a (11:1) Azzur means "helper"; this Jaazaniah is a different man from the one in 8:11.

- b (11:1) Pelatiah means “Yahweh rescues,” which gives point to the question in v. 13.
- c (11:1) Benaiah means “Yahweh has built.”
- d (11:3) Or “The time is not near to build houses.” The image of the pot suggests the leaders saw themselves as the choice meat, safe inside the city.
- e (11:12) Verses 11–12 are not found in the Greek.
- f (11:15) Hebrew: “the men of your redemption,” that is, relatives with the right and duty to redeem family property (Lev 25:25). The Greek has “the men of your captivity.”
- g (11:16) Or “I have been to them a sanctuary in small measure.”
- h (11:19) Some Hebrew manuscripts and the Greek have “another heart”; others render “an undivided heart.”
- i (11:23) That is, the Mount of Olives.

Chapter 12

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 “Son of man, you live among a
rebellious house, people who have eyes for seeing yet see nothing and
ears for hearing yet hear nothing, because they are a house of rebels.
3 “Now you, son of man, get your belongings ready for exile, and in
daylight, with them watching, set out for exile. From where you live,
move to another place while they look on; perhaps they will see it,
even though they are a rebellious house. 4 Bring out your baggage
by day as they watch, like baggage for exile; then in the evening go
out yourself as they watch, like those who go into exile. 5 While they
watch, dig through the wall and carry the baggage out through it. 6
With them watching, hoist it onto your shoulder and take it out at
dusk. Hide your face so that you do not look at the land, because I
have made you an omen to the house of Israel.”
7 I did just as I was commanded. By day I brought out my baggage as
though for exile, and in the evening I dug through the wall with my
hands. I carried it out in the darkness, lifting it onto my shoulder as
they watched.
8 In the morning the word of Yahweh came to me: 9 “Son of man,
did not the Israelites, that rebellious house, ask you, ‘What are you
doing?’ 10 Tell them, ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: This message[a] is
about the prince in Jerusalem and all the Israelites living there.’ 11
Say, ‘I am a sign to you. What I have done will be done to them;

they will go away into exile and captivity.' 12 The prince among them
will hoist his baggage onto his shoulder at dusk and leave; they will
break through the wall to get him out. He will hide his face so that
his eyes do not see the land. 13 I will spread my net over him, and
he will be caught in my snare. I will bring him to Babylon, the land
of the Chaldeans, yet he will not see it, and there he will die.[b] 14 All
who surround him—his attendants and all his soldiers—I will scatter
in every direction, and I will draw a sword and chase after them. 15
Then they will know that I am Yahweh, when I disperse them among
the nations and scatter them through the countries. 16 But I will spare
a few of them from the sword, from famine, and from plague, so that
among the nations where they go they may recount all their abomi-
nations. Then they will know that I am Yahweh."
17 The word of Yahweh came to me: 18 "Son of man, eat your bread
with trembling, and drink your water with shuddering and anxiety.
19 Then tell the people of the land, 'The Lord Yahweh says this about
those living in Jerusalem, in the land of Israel: They will eat their
food in fear and drink their water in horror, because their land will be
emptied of everything in it, on account of the violence of everyone
who lives there. 20 The inhabited towns will be laid waste, and the land
will become a desolation. Then you will know that I am Yahweh.'"
21 The word of Yahweh came to me: 22 "Son of man, what is this proverb
you have in the land of Israel: 'The days drag on, and every vision
comes to nothing'? 23 So tell them, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: I will
end this saying, and it will never again be heard on the lips of Israel.'
Instead tell them, 'The days are at hand, and with them the substance
of every vision. 24 No more will there be empty visions or smooth-
tongued divination among the people of Israel. 25 For I am Yahweh. I
will speak whatever word I speak, and it will be carried out without
further delay. In your days, rebellious house, I will speak the word
and carry it out, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"
26 The word of Yahweh came to me: 27 "Son of man, the house of Israel is
saying, 'The vision he sees is for many days from now; he prophesies
about distant times.' 28 So tell them, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Not

one of my words will be postponed again. The word I speak will be done, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (12:10) Hebrew massa, "burden" or "oracle," a play on the baggage (also something carried) and on the "prince" (nasi, "one lifted up").
- b (12:13) Zedekiah was blinded before he was taken to Babylon (2 Kgs 25:7).

Chapter 13

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "Son of man, prophesy against the prophets of Israel who are prophesying. Say to those who prophesy out of their own imagination, 'Hear the word of Yahweh! 3 This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Woe to the foolish prophets who follow their own spirit and have seen nothing! 4 Your prophets, Israel, have been like jackals among ruins. 5 You did not climb up to the gaps or rebuild the wall for the house of Israel so that it could hold in battle on the day of Yahweh. 6 Their visions are empty and their divining a lie. "Yahweh's declaration," they announce, though Yahweh never sent them; and still they wait for him to make their word come true. 7 Have you not seen a false vision and spoken a lying divination when you say, "Yahweh declares," though I have not spoken? 8 "'Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: Because you have spoken falsehood and seen lies, I am against you, declares the Lord Yahweh. 9 My hand will come down on the prophets whose visions are empty and whose divinations are lies. In the circle of my people they will have no seat; in the roll of Israel's house they will not be written; into Israel's land they will not come. And you will know that I am the Lord Yahweh. 10 "'Because—yes, because—they have led my people astray, saying, "Peace," when there is no peace, and when someone builds a flimsy wall, they coat it with whitewash, 11 tell those who plaster it with whitewash that it is going to collapse. A flooding rain will come, and you, mighty hailstones, will fall, and a stormy wind will break loose. 12 When the wall has collapsed, will anyone not ask you, "Where did the plaster go that you smeared on it?" 13 "'Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: In my fury I will make a storm wind burst out; in my anger there will be torrential rain, and in my fury hailstones to

destroy. 14 I will tear down the wall you coated with whitewash and
level it to the ground, so that its foundation is laid bare. When it falls,
you will perish within it. Then you will know that I am Yahweh. 15
So I will exhaust my anger on the wall and on those who plastered it
with whitewash. And I will tell you, “The wall no longer exists, and
neither do those who plastered it— 16 those prophets of Israel who
prophesied to Jerusalem and beheld for her visions of peace, though
peace there was none, declares the Lord Yahweh.”’
17 “As for you, son of man, set your face against the daughters of your
people who prophesy out of their own imagination. Prophesy against
them 18 and say, ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: Woe to you women who
stitch magic bands[a] on every wrist and fashion veils for heads of every
size, to trap souls! Will you trap the souls of my people and preserve
souls for yourselves? 19 You have disgraced me among my people for
the sake of a few handfuls of barley and some pieces of bread, killing
those who ought not to die and letting live those who ought not to
live, by deceiving my people, who listen to deceit. 20 “Therefore the
Lord Yahweh says this: I am against your magic charms, which you
use to trap people like birds. I will rip them off your arms and release
the people you have been trapping like birds. 21 I will rip away your
veils and snatch my people out of your grip; never again will they be a
catch in your hands. And you will know that I am Yahweh. 22 Because
you have disheartened the righteous with lies, when I had not caused
them grief, and have strengthened the hands of the wicked so that
they do not turn from their evil way and save their lives, 23 so your
empty visions and your divining are finished. I will snatch my people
out of your grip, and you will know that I am Yahweh.’”

Notes

- a (13:18) The meaning of the Hebrew words for “bands” and “veils” is uncertain; they were evidently objects used in magic or divination.

Chapter 14

1 Some of the elders of Israel came to me and sat down in front of me. 2
Then the word of Yahweh came to me: 3 “Son of man, these men have
set up their idols in their hearts and put the stumbling block of their

guilt right before their faces. Should I let them consult me at all? 4 So
talk to them and say to them, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Anyone in
Israel who takes his idols into his heart and puts his sinful obstacle in
front of him, and then goes to the prophet—I, Yahweh, will respond
to him in person, according to his many idols, 5 so that I may seize
the house of Israel by their own hearts, since through their idols they
have all become estranged from me.'
6 "So say to Israel's house, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Come back!
Turn from your idols; turn your faces from every abomination of
yours. 7 When anyone from the Israelites, or any foreigner living
among them, turns away from me, takes his idols into his heart, puts
his sinful obstacle in front of him, and then goes to a prophet to ask
me about something, I, Yahweh, will respond to him in person. 8 I
will set my face against that man and make him a sign and a byword,
and I will cut him off from among my people. Then you will know
that I am Yahweh. 9 "'If the prophet is deceived and speaks a word, I,
Yahweh, have deceived that prophet, and I will stretch out my hand
against him and wipe him out from among my people Israel. 10 They
will bear their guilt; the guilt of the prophet will be the same as the
guilt of the one who consults him, 11 so that the house of Israel will
stray from me no more and no longer make themselves unclean with
all their rebellions. They will be a people to me, and I will be God to
them, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"
12 The word of Yahweh came to me: 13 "Son of man, if a land sins
against me by acting unfaithfully, and I stretch out my hand against
it, break its supply of bread, send famine on it, and cut off from it both
people and animals, 14 if these three men were living there—Noah,
Daniel,[a] and Job—their righteousness would rescue themselves alone,
declares the Lord Yahweh. 15 "If I let wild beasts roam through the
land and they leave it childless, so that it becomes a desolation that
no one passes through because of the beasts, 16 as I live, declares the
Lord Yahweh, even if these three men were in it, they could not save
sons or daughters. They alone would be saved, and the land would
become a desolation. 17 "Or suppose I bring a sword on that country
and command, 'Sword, go through the land!' and cut away from it

human and beast alike; 18 as I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, even if these three men were in it, they could not save sons or daughters; they alone would be saved. 19 "Or if I send a plague into that land and pour out my fury on it in bloodshed, to cut off from it both people and animals, 20 as I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, should Noah, Daniel, and Job be living there, not a son and not a daughter would they rescue. Their righteousness would rescue themselves alone.
21 "The Lord Yahweh says this: How much more severe it will be when I send against Jerusalem my four terrible punishments—sword, hunger, savage animals and disease—to wipe out people and livestock from it! 22 But look, a remnant will be left in it, a band of escapees —sons and daughters led out. They will come out to you, and when you see their ways and their doings, you will be comforted over the evil I brought on Jerusalem, over all that I brought on it. 23 They will console you when you see their conduct and their deeds, for you will know that it was not without cause that I did all I did in it, declares the Lord Yahweh."

Notes

- a (14:14) The Hebrew spelling is Danel (as also in 28:3), the name of a righteous ancient hero known from texts found at Ugarit; Jewish tradition identifies him with the Daniel of the book of Daniel. The name means "God is my judge."

Chapter 15

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "Son of man, what makes the vine's wood any better than wood from other trees—the vine shoot that was among the forest trees? 3 Is wood ever taken from it to make anything useful? Do people make a peg from it to hang any utensil on? 4 No, it is thrown into the fire for fuel. When the fire has consumed both its ends and its middle is charred, is it good for anything? 5 Look, while it was still whole nothing was made from it. How much less, once fire has eaten it and it is scorched, will anything be made from it!
6 "Therefore the Lord Yahweh says this: Just as I made the wood of the vine, out of all the trees in the forest, into fuel for the fire, so I will treat the people living in Jerusalem. 7 I will set my face against them. Though they have escaped the fire, the fire will still consume them.

And you will know that I am Yahweh when I set my face against them. 8 I will make the land a desolation, because they have acted unfaithfully, declares the Lord Yahweh."

Chapter 16

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "Son of man, confront Jerusalem with her abominations 3 and say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this to Jerusalem: Your roots and your birthplace are in Canaan's land. An Amorite was your father, and a Hittite your mother.[a] 4 On the day you were born, no one cut your umbilical cord; you were not bathed in water to make you clean, nor rubbed with salt, nor wrapped in cloth. 5 Nobody looked on you with enough compassion to do any one of these things for you. Instead, you were dumped in an open field, because you were hated on the day of your birth.
6 "'And I passed by you and saw you thrashing in your own blood. In your blood I told you, "Live!" Yes, in your blood I told you, "Live!"[b] 7 I let you multiply like the sprouts of the field. You grew and grew tall and came to the fullest beauty;[c] your breasts took shape and your hair grew long, yet you were naked and exposed. 8 "I came by again and looked at you, and you had reached the time for love. I draped the hem of my cloak over you and hid your nakedness. I pledged myself to you with an oath and made a covenant with you, and you became mine, declares the Lord Yahweh. 9 I bathed you in water, rinsed your blood from you, and rubbed you with oil. 10 I clothed you with embroidered cloth, gave you sandals of fine leather,[d] wrapped you in fine linen, and covered you with silk. 11 I decked you out in ornaments: bangles for your arms, a chain for your neck, 12 I gave you a nose ring, earrings for your ears, and a lovely crown for your head. 13 So you were adorned with gold and silver, and your clothing was fine linen, silk, and embroidered cloth. You ate fine flour, honey, and oil. You became exceedingly beautiful and rose to royalty. 14 Among the nations word of you went out because of your beauty, flawless as it was through the splendor I had put on you, declares the Lord Yahweh.

15 “‘But you trusted in your beauty and used your fame to play the
prostitute. You lavished your favors on anyone who passed by; your
beauty became his.[e] 16 You took some of your clothes and made
colorful shrines for yourself, and on them you acted as a prostitute
—something that should never happen or take place. 17 You also took
your beautiful jewelry of my gold and my silver, which I had given
you, and made for yourself male images, and with them you played
the prostitute. 18 You took your embroidered garments to cover them,
and you set my oil and my incense before them. 19 My food that I
gave you—the finest flour, with olive oil and honey, which I fed
you—you offered before them as a pleasing fragrance. That is what
happened, declares the Lord Yahweh. 20 “‘And you took your sons and
your daughters, children you had borne to me, and slaughtered them
as food for those images. Was your whoring such a small thing? 21
You slaughtered my children and gave them up, making them pass
through the fire to the images. 22 In all your abominations and prosti-
tution you did not remember the days of your youth, when you were
naked and bare, kicking about in your blood.
23 “‘After all your wickedness—woe, woe to you, declares the Lord
Yahweh— 24 you built yourself a mound and made yourself a lofty
shrine in every square. 25 At the head of every street you built your
lofty shrine and made your beauty an abomination. You spread your
legs to everyone who passed by and multiplied your prostitution. 26
You prostituted yourself with the Egyptians, your lustful neighbors,[f]
and multiplied your prostitution to provoke me. 27 So I stretched out
my hand against you, cut back your allotted portion, and handed
you over to the will of those who hate you, the daughters of the
Philistines, who were ashamed of your lewd conduct. 28 You also pros-
tituted yourself with the Assyrians, because you were not satisfied;
you played the prostitute with them, and still you were not satisfied.
29 Then you multiplied your prostitution with the land of merchants,
Chaldea,[g] and even with this you were not satisfied.
30 “‘How feverish[h] your heart is, declares the Lord Yahweh, when you
do all these things, the deeds of a brazen prostitute! 31 When you built
your mound at the head of every street and made your lofty shrine

in every square, you were not like a prostitute, because you scorned payment. 32 Adulterous wife, who takes strangers instead of her husband! 33 Every prostitute is paid, yet you handed out payment to every lover of yours; you bribed them to come in to you from all around for your prostitution. 34 So you were the opposite of other women in your prostitution: no one chased after you to play the prostitute. You paid a fee instead of receiving one; you were the opposite.
35 "'Therefore, prostitute, hear the word of Yahweh. 36 This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Since your lust[i] was spilled out and your naked body was uncovered through your prostitution with your lovers, and through all your detestable idols, and through the blood of your children that you offered to them, 37 that is why I am gathering every lover with whom you took pleasure, everyone you loved and everyone you hated. From all around I will gather them against you; I will uncover your nakedness before them, and they will look on all of it. 38 I will sentence you with the sentence for women who commit adultery and murder, and I will make you the victim of bloody rage and jealousy. 39 I will give you into their hands; your mound they will pull down and your lofty shrines they will break apart. They will peel off your clothing and carry away your fine jewels, and they will leave you naked and exposed. 40 They will bring up a mob against you, stone you, and hack you to pieces with their swords. 41 They will set your houses on fire and carry out sentences against you while many women look on. I will put an end to your prostitution, and you will never pay lovers again. 42 Then my fury against you will be spent, my jealousy will depart from you, and I will grow quiet and be angry no more. 43 You did not bear in mind the time of your youth; you raged at me with all of this. So now I am bringing your ways back on your head, declares the Lord Yahweh. Did you not add this lewdness to all your abominations?
44 "'Look, everyone who quotes proverbs will quote this one about you: "Like mother, like daughter." 45 You are the daughter of your mother, who despised her husband and her children; and you are the sister of your sisters, who despised their husbands and children. Your mother was a Hittite, and your father was an Amorite. 46 Your

older sister is Samaria, who lives with her daughters to your north,[j] and your younger sister, who lives to your south, is Sodom with her daughters. 47 Not content to follow in their ways and do their abominations, you soon became, as if that were a trifle, more depraved than they in all you did. 48 As I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, Sodom your sister and her daughters did not do what you have done, you and your daughters. 49 See, this was the guilt of Sodom your sister: pride, a surplus of bread, and untroubled ease were hers and her daughters', yet the hand of the poor and needy they did not strengthen. 50 They grew lofty and did abomination before me, so I took them away, as you have seen.[k] 51 Samaria's sins were not half of yours. Your abominations outnumber hers, and by all you have done you have made your sisters look righteous. 52 You also must carry your shame, since you have pleaded your sisters' case. Your sins were so much more abominable than theirs that they look more righteous than you. Be ashamed, then, and carry your shame, because you have made your sisters look righteous.

53 "'Yet I will turn back their captivity—Sodom's and her daughters', Samaria's and her daughters'—and yours too in their midst, 54 that you may carry your shame and blush for everything you did, becoming a comfort to them. 55 Your sisters Sodom and her daughters and Samaria and her daughters will return to their former condition, and you and your daughters will return to your former condition. 56 In your proud days you would not so much as mention your sister Sodom, 57 before your own evil was exposed? Now you have become like her, scorned by the daughters of Edom[l] and all the neighbors around her, and by the daughters of the Philistines—everyone around you who looks down on you. 58 Your lewdness and your abominations—you carry them, declares Yahweh.

59 "'For this is what the Lord Yahweh says: I will deal with you as you have done, you who have despised the oath by breaking the covenant. 60 Yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish an everlasting covenant with you. 61 You will recall your ways and be humiliated when you take in your sisters, those older and those younger than you. I will give them to

you as daughters, though not by your covenant. [62] I will establish my covenant with you, and you will know that I am Yahweh, [63] so that you remember and feel shame, and because of your humiliation never open your mouth again, when I forgive you for all you did, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (16:3) The Amorites and Hittites were among the peoples living in Canaan before Israel (Gen 15:19–21); the point is that Jerusalem's origins were pagan.
- b (16:6) The Greek lacks the repeated sentence "I said to you as you lay in your blood, 'Live!'"
- c (16:7) The Hebrew is uncertain; it may mean "you came to have the finest ornaments."
- d (16:10) Hebrew tahash, a fine leather of uncertain kind, perhaps from dolphins or sea cows.
- e (16:15) The Hebrew phrase "your beauty became his" is uncertain.
- f (16:26) Hebrew: "great of flesh," a sexual euphemism.
- g (16:29) Or "Chaldea, the land of merchants." Hebrew: "the land of Canaan, Chaldea"; "Canaan" here means "merchants."
- h (16:30) Or "weak"; the meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- i (16:36) Hebrew nechosheth, perhaps "copper" (that is, money) or "lust"; the meaning is uncertain.
- j (16:46) Hebrew: "on your left"; the right and left referred to south and north for someone facing east.
- k (16:50) Or "as you have seen."
- l (16:57) So some ancient witnesses; the main Hebrew text and the Greek have "Aram" (Syria). In Hebrew the two names differ by one similar letter.

Chapter 17

[1] The word of Yahweh came to me:

[2] "Son of man, pose a riddle and tell a parable to the house of Israel.

[3] Say, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says:

A great eagle with great wings, long pinions,
and full plumage of many colors
came to Lebanon and took the top of the cedar.

[4] He broke off its highest twig
and took it to a land of merchants;
he planted it in a city of traders.

5 Then he took some of the seed of the land
and planted it in fertile soil;
he set it like a willow beside abundant waters.[a]
6 It sprouted and became a spreading vine, low in height;
its branches turned toward him,
and its roots stayed beneath him.
So it became a vine, produced branches, and sent out shoots.
7 "'Then came a second great eagle,
broad of wing and thick with feathers.
And see, this vine twisted its roots toward him
and sent its tendrils reaching to him,
away from the bed where it grew,
for him to water it.
8 It had been planted in good soil beside abundant waters,
so that it could produce branches and bear fruit
and become a magnificent vine.'
9 "Say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Will it prosper? Will its roots not be torn out and its fruit stripped away, until every new leaf it puts forth dries up? No mighty arm, no crowd of people, will be needed to wrench it up by the roots.
10 Look—it is replanted; will it prosper? Once the east wind touches it, will it not dry up entirely, dry up in the very bed where it sprouted?'"
11 The word of Yahweh came to me: 12 "Say to the rebellious house: 'Don't you know the meaning of these things?' Tell them: 'Jerusalem was entered by the king of Babylon, who seized its king and its princes and brought them back with him to Babylon.[b] 13 He took one of royal descent[c] and cut a covenant with him, binding him by a curse-oath. The land's men of power he carried away, 14 so that the kingdom would be kept low and not lift itself up, but would survive by keeping his covenant. 15 But that king revolted against him, sending his messengers down to Egypt for horses and a host of troops. Will he prosper? Will a man who does these things get away? He has broken the covenant—will he get away? 16 "'As I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, in the place of the king who enthroned him, whose curse-oath he scorned and whose covenant he broke—with him, in

the middle of Babylon, he will die. 17 Pharaoh, for all his great force
and vast assembly, will do nothing for him in the battle, when the
siege mound is heaped up and the siege tower built for cutting down
many souls. 18 He despised the oath by breaking the covenant. He gave
his hand in pledge and yet did all these things; he will not escape.
19 "'So the Lord Yahweh says this: As I live, my curse-oath that he
scorned and my covenant that he broke—I will lay them on his head.
20 I will throw my net over him, and he will be trapped in my snare. I
will take him to Babylon and hold a trial there over the treachery he
committed against me. 21 All his elite troops[d] in every unit will fall by
the sword, and whoever remains will be blown to every wind. Then
you will know that I, Yahweh, have spoken.'
22 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says:

I myself will take a sprig from the high crown of the cedar and
plant it;
from the topmost of its young shoots I will break off a tender one
and plant it myself on a tall, lofty mountain.
23 On Israel's lofty mountain I will plant it;
it will put out branches and bear fruit
and become a majestic cedar.
Every kind of winged creature will dwell beneath it,
sheltering in the shade of its boughs.
24 Then all the trees of the field will know
that I, Yahweh, bring low the high tree
and make the low tree tall,
dry up the green tree
and make the dry tree flourish.
I, Yahweh, have spoken, and I will do it."

Notes

- a (17:5) The Hebrew word rendered "willow" is uncertain.
- b (17:12) This was Nebuchadnezzar's deportation of King Jehoiachin in 597 BC (2 Kgs 24:10–17).
- c (17:13) That is, Zedekiah (2 Kgs 24:17).
- d (17:21) So some ancient witnesses; the main Hebrew text has "fugitives."

Chapter 18

1 The word of Yahweh came to me:
2 “What do you mean, you who keep quoting this saying concerning
Israel’s land:
‘The fathers eat unripe grapes,
and it is the children’s teeth that go numb’?
3 As surely as I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, you will never again
quote this proverb in Israel.
4 Look, all souls are mine. As the father’s soul is mine, so the son’s
soul is mine. The soul that sins—that soul shall die.
5 “Take a man who is righteous, who practices justice and right. 6 On
the mountains he does not feast at shrines; he does not raise his eyes
to the idols of Israel’s house. His neighbor’s wife he does not defile,
and he does not come near a woman in her time of impurity. 7 He
wrongs no one; the pledge he took for a debt he gives back. He seizes
nothing by robbery; his bread he gives to the hungry, and the naked
he clothes with a garment. 8 He does not lend at interest or take a
profit. He keeps his hand from wrongdoing and judges fairly between
one person and another. 9 He walks in my statutes and keeps my
judgments, acting faithfully. Such a man is righteous; he will surely
live, declares the Lord Yahweh.
10 “Now let him father a son who is a robber, one who sheds blood
and does any one of these things 11 (though the father did none of
them): he eats at the mountain shrines, defiles his neighbor’s wife,
12 oppresses the poor and needy, commits robbery, does not return
the pledge, lifts his eyes to the idols, commits abomination, 13 lends at
interest and charges a premium. Will such a son live? No, he will not
live! Since he has done all these detestable things, he will certainly
die, and his death will be his own fault.
14 “But now let this man father a son who observes all the sins his
father has done; he observes them and does nothing like them. 15 On
the mountains he does not feast at shrines; he does not raise his eyes
to the idols of Israel’s house. His neighbor’s wife he does not defile.
16 He wrongs no one; he holds back no pledge and seizes nothing by
robbery. His bread he gives to the hungry, and the naked he clothes

with a garment. 17 He holds back his hand from the poor,[a] takes neither
interest nor increase, does my judgments, and follows my statutes.
He shall not die because of his father's guilt; he shall surely live. 18 His
father, since he extorted and robbed a brother and did what was evil
among his own people—look, he shall die in his guilt.
19 "Yet you ask, 'Why does the son not bear the guilt of his father?'
When the son has done what is just and right and has kept all my
statutes and carried them out, he will surely live. 20 The soul that sins
—that soul shall die. A son shall not carry his father's guilt, and a
father shall not carry his son's guilt. On the righteous rests his own
righteousness, and on the wicked rests his own wickedness.
21 "But should the wicked man turn back from all the sins he did,
guard all my statutes, and practice justice and right, he shall surely
live; he shall not die. 22 None of the transgressions he has committed
will be remembered against him; because of the righteousness he
has practiced, he will live. 23 Do I take any pleasure in the death of
the wicked, declares the Lord Yahweh? Would I not rather that he
turn from his ways and live? 24 "But if a righteous man abandons
his righteousness and commits injustice, doing the same detestable
things that the wicked do, will he live? None of the righteous things
he did will be counted. Because of the treachery he has committed
and the sins he has done, he will die for them.
25 "Still you say, 'The Lord's way does not measure up.' Hear now,
house of Israel: Does my way not measure up? Is it not rather your
ways that fail to measure up? 26 When a righteous person turns from
his righteousness and does wrong, he will die for it; for the wrong
he has done he will die. 27 And once the wicked man turns back from
the wickedness he did and practices justice and right, he will keep
his soul alive. 28 Because he considered and turned away from all the
transgressions he had committed, he will surely live; he will not die. 29
Yet the house of Israel says, 'The Lord's way is not fair.' Are my ways
unfair, house of Israel? Is it not your ways that are unfair?
30 "Therefore I will judge you, house of Israel, each according to his
ways, declares the Lord Yahweh. Repent and turn away from all your
transgressions, so that guilt will not be your downfall. 31 Cast away

from you every rebellion of yours that you have done, and make for yourselves a heart that is new and a spirit that is new. Why will you die, house of Israel? 32 I take no delight in anyone's death, declares the Lord Yahweh. So repent, and live!"

Notes

- a (18:17) So the main Hebrew text; the Greek has "from injustice" (compare v. 8).

Chapter 19

1 "And you—raise a dirge over Israel's princes,
2 and say:
'What a lioness your mother was among the lions!
She lay down among young lions;
she reared her cubs.
3 She brought up one of her cubs;
he became a young lion.
He learned to tear prey;
he devoured people.
4 Nations got word of him;
in their pit he was taken.
With hooks they hauled him off
to Egypt's land.[a]
5 "'When she saw that her hope was lost,
that what she had waited for had come to nothing,
she took another of her cubs
and made him a young lion.
6 He prowled among the lions;
he became a young lion.
He learned to tear prey;
he devoured people.
7 He knew their strongholds[b]
and laid waste their towns.
The land and all that filled it were appalled
at the sound of his roaring.
8 Then the nations set against him
the provinces on every side.

They spread their net over him;
he was caught in their pit.
9 They put hooks in him and locked him in a cage,
then brought him to the king of Babylon.[c]
They took him into strongholds
so his roar would never again be heard
over the mountains of Israel.
10 "'Your mother was like a vine in your vineyard,[d]
planted beside the waters.
It was fruitful and full of branches
because of abundant water.
11 It had strong branches,
fit for rulers' scepters.
It towered high
among the thick foliage;
it was conspicuous for its height
and its many branches.
12 But in fury it was torn out
and flung to the earth.
Its fruit was parched by the east wind;
its mighty boughs broke away and dried;
fire devoured them.
13 Now it is planted in the wilderness,
in a dry and thirsty land.
14 Fire has gone out from its main branch
and consumed its shoots and fruit,
so that it has no strong branch left,
no scepter for ruling.'
This is a lament, and it has become a lament."

Notes

- a (19:4) This was King Jehoahaz, taken to Egypt by Pharaoh Neco in 609 BC (2 Kgs 23:31–34).
- b (19:7) Hebrew: "He knew his widows"; a slight change gives "he broke down their strongholds" or "he ravaged their widows."
- c (19:9) Probably King Jehoiachin (2 Kgs 24:8–15) or Zedekiah (2 Kgs 25:7).

- d (19:10) Hebrew: “in your blood”; the text is uncertain, and many scholars emend it to “in a vineyard.”

Chapter 20

1 In the seventh year, on the tenth day of the fifth month (in July–
August),[a] some of the elders of Israel came to consult Yahweh, and
they sat down before me. 2 Then the word of Yahweh came to me: 3
“Son of man, speak to the elders of Israel and tell them, ‘This is what
the Lord Yahweh says: Have you come to consult me? As I live, I
will not let myself be consulted by you, declares the Lord Yahweh.’ 4
“Will you judge them? Will you judge them, son of man? Then make
known to them the abominations of their ancestors. 5 Tell them, ‘The
Lord Yahweh says this: On the day I chose Israel, I lifted my hand in
oath to the seed of Jacob’s house, and in Egypt’s land I made myself
known to them. I lifted my hand to them, saying, “I am Yahweh your
God.” 6 That day I lifted my hand to them, swearing to lead them out of
Egypt’s land to a land I had scouted for them, one flowing with milk
and honey, the jewel of every land. 7 And I said to them, “Each of you,
throw away the detestable things your eyes feast on, and do not defile
yourselves with the idols of Egypt. I am Yahweh your God.” 8 “‘They
rebelled against me and would not hear me. Not one cast away the
vile things that held his eyes, and Egypt’s idols they did not abandon.
So I spoke of pouring my fury on them, of exhausting my anger on
them right there in Egypt’s land. 9 Yet I acted for my name’s sake,
to keep it from being profaned before the nations they lived among,
before whose eyes I had revealed myself to them by leading them out
of Egypt’s land. 10 So out of Egypt’s land I led them, and I brought them
to the wilderness. 11 I gave them my statutes and made known to them
my judgments, by which a person who carries them out will live. 12
My Sabbaths too I gave them, to be a sign between me and them,
for knowing that I am Yahweh who sets them apart as holy. 13 “‘But
the house of Israel rebelled against me in the wilderness. They did
not walk in my statutes, and they rejected my judgments, by which a
person who carries them out will live, and they utterly profaned my
Sabbaths. So I resolved to pour out my fury on them in the wilderness

to wipe them out. 14 Yet I acted for my name's sake, to keep it from
being profaned before the nations, in whose view I had led them
out. 15 And I, too, lifted my hand to them in the wilderness, swearing
not to bring them into the land I had given, the land flowing with
milk and honey, the jewel of every land, 16 because they rejected my
judgments, did not walk in my statutes, and profaned my Sabbaths;
for their hearts went after their idols. 17 But my eye took pity on them,
and I held back from destroying them; I did not make a full end of
them in the wilderness.
18 "'I told their children in the wilderness, "Do not follow the rules
of your parents, or observe their laws, or make yourselves unclean
with their idols. 19 I am Yahweh your God. Walk in my statutes, keep
my judgments, and carry them out. 20 Keep my Sabbaths holy, so that
they will be a sign between me and you, and you will know that I
am Yahweh your God." 21 "'But the children defied me. They did not
follow my rules or carefully observe my laws, which give life to the
one who obeys them, and they desecrated my Sabbaths. So I said I
would pour out my rage on them and let my anger run its course
against them in the wilderness. 22 Yet I drew back my hand and acted
for my name's sake, to keep it from being profaned before the nations
in whose view I had led them out. 23 In addition, I swore to them in the
wilderness, with my hand raised, that I would scatter them among
the nations and spread them across the lands, 24 because they had not
carried out my judgments but had rejected my statutes and profaned
my Sabbaths, and their eyes were fixed on their fathers' idols. 25 So
I gave them rules that were not good and laws that could not give
them life. 26 I made them unclean by their own gifts, as they made
every firstborn pass through the fire,[b] that I might appall them, and
that they might know that I am Yahweh.'
27 "Therefore, son of man, speak to the house of Israel and tell them,
'This is what the Lord Yahweh says: In this also your ancestors blas-
phemed me by acting unfaithfully toward me. 28 For I brought them
into the land that I had lifted my hand to give them, and wherever
they saw a lofty hill or a leafy tree, they slaughtered their sacrifices
there, there they set their offerings that provoked me, there they

laid their soothing aromas, and there they poured out their drink offerings. 29 So I said to them, “What is this high place you go to?” And it is called Bamah[c] to this day.’

30 “Therefore tell the Israelites, ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: Are you going to make yourselves unclean as your ancestors did, and chase after their vile idols? 31 When you present your offerings and send your sons through the fire, you make yourselves unclean with all your idols even now. Am I to answer your inquiries, Israelites? As I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, I will not answer your inquiries. 32 What you have in mind will never happen—when you say, “Let us be like the nations, like the clans of the countries, serving wood and stone.” 33 “‘As I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, with a mighty hand, an outstretched arm, and outpoured fury I will rule as king over you. 34 I will bring you out from the peoples and gather you from the countries where you are scattered, with a mighty hand, an outstretched arm, and outpoured fury. 35 I will bring you into the wilderness of the peoples, and there I will enter into judgment with you face to face. 36 Just as I put your ancestors on trial in the wilderness of Egypt, so I will put you on trial, declares the Lord Yahweh. 37 I will make you pass beneath my staff and bring you under the obligation of the covenant.[d] 38 I will sift out from you the rebels and those who revolt against me. From the land where they sojourn I will lead them out, but Israel’s soil they shall not enter. And you will know that I am Yahweh. 39 “‘And you, house of Israel, the Lord Yahweh says this: Go, every one of you, serve his idols! But afterward—surely you will listen to me, and my holy name you will profane no more with your gifts and idols. 40 For it is on my holy mountain, on Israel’s lofty mountain, declares the Lord Yahweh, that the entire house of Israel will serve me, all of it in the land. There I will welcome them with pleasure, and there I will ask for your contributions, the first and best of your gifts, and all your holy things. 41 Like a soothing aroma I will welcome you with pleasure when I lead you out of the peoples and collect you from the lands of your scattering; and through you I will show myself holy before the nations’ eyes. 42 Then you will know that I am Yahweh, when I bring you into the land of Israel, the land I raised my hand in an oath to

give to your ancestors. 43 There you will remember how you lived and
all the actions that made you unclean, and you will be disgusted with
yourselves for all the evil you committed. 44 You will know that I am
Yahweh when I act toward you for my name's sake and not according
to your evil ways or your corrupt actions, Israelites, declares the Lord
Yahweh.'"
45 The word of Yahweh came to me:[e] 46 "Son of man, set your face
toward the south. Preach against the south and prophesy against the
forest of the Negev.[f] 47 Say to the forest of the Negev, 'Hear Yahweh's
word. The Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am setting a fire in you;
every tree in you, green or dry, it will devour. The fierce flame will
not be put out, and from the Negev to the north every face will be
seared by it. 48 All flesh will see that I, Yahweh, have kindled it; it will
not be quenched.'" 49 Then I said, "Ah, Lord Yahweh! They are saying
of me, 'Is he not just a maker of parables?'"

Notes

- a (20:1) Hebrew: "in the fifth month, on the tenth of the month," counting from the spring new year; this was the month later called Av, in 591 BC. The Greek has only "on the fifteenth of the month."
- b (20:26) Or "when they offered up every firstborn"; compare 16:21.
- c (20:29) Bamah means "high place." Ezekiel plays on the sound of the question "What (mah) is the high place to which you go (ba'im)?"
- d (20:37) The Greek has "and I will bring you in by number"; the meaning of the Hebrew word rendered "bond" is uncertain.
- e (20:45) In Hebrew, 20:45–49 is numbered 21:1–5, and 21:1–32 is numbered 21:6–37.
- f (20:46) The Negev is the dry region south of Judah; "south" here also represents Judah and Jerusalem (21:2).

Chapter 21

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "Son of man, set your face toward
Jerusalem and preach against the sanctuaries. Prophesy against the
land of Israel 3 and say to Israel's land, 'Yahweh says this: Look, I am
coming at you. My sword I will draw out of its sheath, and from you
I will cut away righteous and wicked alike. 4 Because I am going to
cut off from you both righteous and wicked, my sword will go out of
its sheath against all flesh from south to north. 5 Then all flesh will

know that I, Yahweh, have drawn my sword from its sheath; it will not return to it again.'

6 "As for you, son of man, groan! Groan before their eyes with breaking heart[a] and bitter grief. 7 When they ask you, 'Why are you groaning?' say, 'Because of the news that is coming. Every heart will melt, every hand go limp, every spirit grow faint, and every knee run with water. Look, it is coming, and it will happen, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

8 The word of Yahweh came to me:

9 "Son of man, prophesy and say, 'This is what my Lord says: Say:

A sword, a sword is sharpened
and also polished—

10 sharpened for slaughter,
polished to flash like lightning!
Shall we rejoice? The scepter of my son despises every tree.[b]

11 He has handed it over for burnishing,
for the palm to grip;
sharpened is this sword, burnished too,
to be placed in the killer's hand.'

12 Shout and howl, son of man, for this sword is for my people, for every prince of Israel; they are tossed to it together with my people. So slap your thigh.[c]

13 For a testing has come—and what if the scepter that despises is no more? declares the Lord Yahweh.[d]

14 "And you, son of man, prophesy and strike your hands together.

Let the sword come down twice, even three times—
the sword of the dead,
the sword of the great slaughter,
closing in on them,

15 so that hearts may melt
and the stumbling may be many.
At all their gates I have set the slaughter of the sword.[e]
Ah! It is made to flash like lightning;
it is grasped for slaughter.

16 Cut hard to the right!
Turn and strike to the left,
wherever your blade is aimed.
17 I too will strike my hands together
and let my rage be satisfied.
I, Yahweh, have spoken."
18 The word of Yahweh came to me: 19 "As for you, son of man, mark out two roads for the sword of the king of Babylon to take, both starting from the same land. Make a signpost and put it at the head of the road to a city. 20 Mark out a road for the sword to come to Rabbah of the Ammonites, and another to Judah, to fortified Jerusalem. 21 For Babylon's king has halted where the road parts, where the two ways begin, to seek an omen. He rattles the arrows, inquires of the household gods,[f] and examines a liver. 22 In his right hand he holds the divination lot for Jerusalem, directing him to position battering rams, to give the command to kill, to shout the war cry, to place battering rams against the gates, to build an earthen ramp, and to construct siege towers. 23 To those who have sworn solemn oaths,[g] it will seem a false divination; but he will bring their guilt to remembrance, so that they will be captured.
24 "Therefore the Lord Yahweh says this: Since you have made your guilt known through your open rebellion, revealing your sins in everything you do—since you have made yourselves known, you will be seized by force. 25 And you, defiled and wicked one, Israel's prince, your day has arrived, the hour when guilt reaches its end, 26 the Lord Yahweh says this: Take off the turban; lift away the crown! This will not stay this way. Raise up what is low; pull down what is high. 27 A ruin, a ruin, a ruin I will make it! This too will not happen until he comes to whom judgment belongs, and I will give it to him.[h]
28 "And you, son of man, prophesy and say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this about the Ammonites and their scorn:
A sword! A sword unsheathed for the slaughter,
burnished to devour, to gleam like a lightning bolt—
29 while they divine emptiness for you
and see lying omens for you—

to place you on the necks of the slain, the wicked,
whose day has arrived,
the hour when guilt reaches its end.
30 Return it to its sheath!
In the place where you were created,
in the land of your origin, I will judge you.
31 I will pour out my indignation on you;
I will blow on you with the fire of my wrath.
I will hand you over to brutal men,
skilled in destruction.
32 You will be fuel for the fire;
your blood will be in the midst of the land.
You will not be remembered,
for I, Yahweh, have spoken.'"

Notes

- a (21:6) Hebrew: "with breaking of loins."
- b (21:10) The Hebrew of this line is very obscure, and any rendering is a guess.
- c (21:12) A gesture of grief or alarm (Jer 31:19).
- d (21:13) The Hebrew of v. 13 is very obscure.
- e (21:15) The meaning of the Hebrew word rendered "slaughter" here is uncertain.
- f (21:21) Hebrew teraphim, figurines used in divination (Gen 31:19).
- g (21:23) The meaning of the Hebrew phrase is uncertain; it may refer to the oaths of loyalty sworn to the king of Babylon.
- h (21:27) Or "until he comes whose right it is." The wording echoes Gen 49:10.

Chapter 22

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "As for you, son of man, will you judge? Will you judge the city of bloodshed? Then confront her with all her abominations. 3 Say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: O city that sheds blood within her walls, bringing her day of doom, and that makes idols to make herself unclean! 4 You have become guilty by the blood you have shed and defiled by the idols you have made. You have brought your days near and arrived at the end of your years. Therefore I have made you a reproach to the nations and a mockery to all the countries. 5 Those near and those far from you will mock you, you of defiled name, full of turmoil.

6 "'Look, the princes of Israel within you, each according to his power,
have been bent on shedding blood. 7 In you they have treated father
and mother with contempt; in your midst they have oppressed the
foreigner; in you they have wronged the fatherless and the widow.
8 You have despised my holy things and profaned my Sabbaths. 9
Men who peddle slander to spill blood are in you; men who feast at
mountain shrines are in you; lewdness they practice in your midst.
10 A father's nakedness is uncovered[a] in you; a woman unclean in
her impurity is forced in you. 11 With his neighbor's wife one man
does abomination; another defiles his daughter-in-law by lewdness;
another in you forces his sister, his father's daughter. 12 Within you
people accept bribes to shed blood. You charge interest and make a
profit, and you get rich by cheating your neighbors. And you have
forgotten me, declares the Lord Yahweh.
13 "'So look, I clap my hands over the profit you have plundered and
over the blood that is shed within you. 14 Will your courage endure, or
your hands stay strong, in the days when I deal with you? I, Yahweh,
have spoken, and I will do it. 15 I will scatter you among the nations
and spread you across the lands, and I will put an end to the filth in
you. 16 You will be profaned[b] through your own doing in the sight of
the nations. Then you will know that I am Yahweh.'"
17 The word of Yahweh came to me: 18 "Son of man, the house of Israel
has become dross to me. All of them are copper, tin, iron, and lead
inside a furnace; they are the dross of silver. 19 Therefore the Lord
Yahweh says this: Because every one of you has turned into scrap
metal, I will gather you together inside Jerusalem. 20 As people gather
silver, copper, iron, lead, and tin into a furnace to blow fire on it and
melt it, so I will gather you in my anger and fury, put you inside, and
melt you. 21 I will gather you and blow on you with the fire of my
wrath, and you will be melted within the city. 22 As silver is melted in
a furnace, so you will be melted inside it. Then you will know that I,
Yahweh, have poured out my fury on you."
23 The word of Yahweh came to me: 24 "Son of man, say to her, 'You are a
land that has not been cleansed or rained upon in the day of indigna-
tion.' 25 There is a conspiracy of her prophets[c] within her, like a roaring

lion tearing its prey. They devour lives, seize treasure and precious things, and multiply the widows within her. 26 Her priests wrong my teaching and treat my holy things as profane. Between sacred and common they draw no line; the difference between unclean and clean they never make known. From my Sabbaths they hide their eyes, and among them I am made profane. 27 Her officials within her are like wolves tearing prey, shedding blood and destroying lives to get unjust gain. 28 Her prophets daub whitewash over all of it, seeing empty visions and divining lies, and declaring, 'The Lord Yahweh says this,' though Yahweh never spoke. 29 The common people have extorted and robbed; the poor and the needy they have mistreated, and the foreigner they have wronged without justice. 30 I looked among them for one man to repair the wall, to take his stand before me in the gap for the land so that I would not wreck it—and there was none. 31 So I have poured out my indignation on them; I have consumed them with the fire of my wrath. I have brought their conduct down on their own heads, declares the Lord Yahweh."

Notes

- a (22:10) That is, they have sexual relations with their fathers' wives (Lev 18:8).
- b (22:16) So the main Hebrew text. The Greek reads differently ("I will give inheritances in you").
- c (22:25) The Greek has "her princes," which many scholars prefer since prophets are treated in v. 28.

Chapter 23

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 "Son of man, there were two women, daughters of one mother. 3 They became prostitutes in Egypt; they played the prostitute in their youth. There their breasts were fondled, and there their virgin nipples were caressed. 4 The elder bore the name Oholah,[a] her sister the name Oholibah.[b] They became mine and gave birth to sons and daughters. Their names stand for this: Oholah is Samaria, and Oholibah is Jerusalem.

5 "Oholah went whoring though she was mine. She burned with desire for her lovers, for Assyria's warriors[c] 6 clothed in blue, governors and commanders, all of them desirable young men, horsemen riding on horses. 7 She bestowed her prostitution on them, all of them the elite

of Assyria, and she defiled herself with all the idols of everyone she
lusted after. 8 She did not abandon the prostitution she had begun
in Egypt; in her youth men had slept with her, fondled her young
breasts, and spilled out their lust on her. 9 So I gave her over into her
lovers' hands, into the hands of the Assyrians she burned for. 10 They
exposed her nakedness, took her sons and daughters, and killed her
with the sword. She became a byword among women, and judgments
were carried out on her.
11 "Her sister Oholibah saw this, yet in her lust she was more corrupt
than her sister, and her prostitution exceeded her sister's. 12 She lusted
after the Assyrians—governors and commanders, warriors clothed
in splendor, horsemen riding on horses, all of them desirable young
men. 13 I saw that she too was defiled; the two of them went one
road. 14 But she carried her prostitution further. She saw men carved
on the wall, images of Chaldeans engraved in vermilion, 15 with belts
around their waists and flowing turbans on their heads, all of them
looking like officers, a portrait of Babylonians whose native land was
Chaldea. 16 As soon as she saw them, she lusted after them and sent
messengers to them in Chaldea. 17 Babylon's sons came in to her, to
the bed of love, and made her unclean with their whoring; and when
they had defiled her, she pulled herself away from them in revulsion.
18 When she flaunted her prostitution and exposed her nakedness, I
turned from her in disgust, just as I had turned from her sister. 19 Yet
she multiplied her prostitution, remembering the days of her youth
when she played the prostitute in the land of Egypt. 20 She burned for
her lovers there, men with flesh like a donkey's flesh and an issue
like a stallion's issue. 21 So you longed for the lewdness of your youth,
when the Egyptians caressed your nipples and fondled your young
breasts.[d]
22 "So, Oholibah, the Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am rousing against
you the lovers from whom you pulled away in revulsion; from all
around I will bring them against you— 23 Babylon's sons and every
Chaldean, Pekod, Shoa, and Koa,[e] and with them all Assyria's sons
—handsome young men every one, governors and prefects, captains
and summoned men, every one mounted on horses. 24 They will attack

you with weapons,[f] chariots and carts, and with a huge assembly of peoples. On every side they will take their stand against you, armed with large shields, small shields and helmets. I will entrust the judgment to them, and they will sentence you by their own laws. 25 I will turn my jealous anger on you, and they will treat you furiously. They will slice off your nose and ears, and your survivors will die by the sword. They will carry off your sons and daughters, and your survivors will be burned up in the fire. 26 They will strip you of your clothes and take away your beautiful jewelry. 27 So I will put an end to your lewdness and the prostitution you brought from the land of Egypt. You will not lift your eyes to them or remember Egypt anymore.

28 "For the Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am giving you into the hands of the ones you hate, the ones from whom you pulled away in revulsion.

29 They will treat you with hatred and take everything you earned, leaving you stripped and naked. Your shameful prostitution will be uncovered—your indecency and your prostitution.

30 These things will be done to you because you prostituted yourself with the nations and defiled yourself with their idols.

31 Your sister's road you have walked, so her cup I will set in your hand.

32 "The Lord Yahweh says:

Your sister's cup you will drink,
the cup that is deep and broad;
you will be laughed at and mocked,
for it holds so much.

33 With drunkenness and grief you will be filled;
a cup of ruin and desolation
is your sister Samaria's cup.

34 You will drink it and drain it,
gnaw its broken pieces,
and tear your breasts.
For I have spoken, declares the Lord Yahweh.

35 “Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: Because you have
forgotten me and thrown me behind your back, you must bear the
penalty of your lewdness and your prostitution.”
36 Yahweh said to me, “Son of man, will you judge Oholah and
Oholibah? Then declare to them their abominations. 37 For they
have committed adultery, and there is blood on their hands. They
have committed adultery with their idols; they have even made the
children they bore to me pass through the fire to them as food. 38
Moreover, they have done this to me: on that same day they defiled
my sanctuary and profaned my Sabbaths. 39 For when they had
slaughtered their children for their idols, on that same day they came
into my sanctuary to profane it. That is what they did in the middle
of my house. 40 “They even sent for men coming from far away; a
messenger was sent to them, and they came. For them you bathed,
painted your eyes, and adorned yourself with jewelry. 41 On a magnif-
icent couch you sat, a table laid out in front of it, and on it you placed
my incense and my oil. 42 The sound of a carefree crowd was around
her, with men of the common sort brought in, drunkards[g] from the
wilderness. They put bracelets on the women’s wrists and beautiful
crowns on their heads. 43 Then I said of her who was worn out by
adulteries, ‘Now they will commit prostitution with her, even her!’ 44
And they went in to her as one goes in to a prostitute. So they went
in to Oholah and to Oholibah, the lewd women. 45 But righteous men
will judge them with the sentence for adulteresses and the sentence
for women who shed blood, because they are adulteresses and there
is blood on their hands.
46 “For this is what the Lord Yahweh says: Bring up an assembly
against them, and hand them over to terror and plunder. 47 The
assembly will pelt them with stones and hack them with swords;
their sons and daughters will be killed and their houses burned down.
48 So I will put an end to lewdness in the land, and all women will
take warning and not imitate your lewdness. 49 Your lewdness will be
repaid on you, and you will bear the penalty for your sins with idols.
Then you will know that I am the Lord Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (23:4) Oholah means "her tent," perhaps alluding to Samaria's own shrines.
- b (23:4) Oholibah means "my tent is in her," alluding to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem.
- c (23:5) Or "neighbors"; the Hebrew word can mean "near."
- d (23:21) The Hebrew of this line is difficult; "the Egyptians" is implied from v. 19.
- e (23:23) Pekod, Shoa, and Koa were peoples east of the Tigris; the names may also be wordplays on Hebrew words for "punishment" and "cry for help." The Greek has "Phacuc, Sue, and Hychue."
- f (23:24) The meaning of the Hebrew word rendered "weapons" is uncertain.
- g (23:42) Or "Sabeans," following the written Hebrew text; the meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 24

1 In the ninth year, on the tenth day of the tenth month (in December–
January),[a] the word of Yahweh came to me:
2 "Son of man, record for yourself the date, this very day. On this exact
day Babylon's king has closed in on Jerusalem.
3 Tell a parable to the rebellious house and say to them, 'This is what
the Lord Yahweh says:
    Set the pot on the fire, set it on;
    pour water into it as well.
4 Gather its pieces into it,
    every choice piece, the thigh and the shoulder;
    pack it full of the best bones.
5 Take the choicest of the flock;
    pile the bones[b] under it.
    Bring it to a rolling boil;
    let its bones seethe in it.
6 "'So the Lord Yahweh says this:
    Woe to the city of blood,
    the pot with corrosion[c] inside,
    whose corrosion will not come out!
    Take it out, piece after piece;
    cast no lot for it.[d]
7 For her blood remains inside her;
    on bare rock she set it.

She never spilled it on the soil
where dust might hide it.
8 To stir up fury, to take vengeance,
I have put her blood on the bare rock,
so that it would not be covered.
9 "'Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says:
Woe to the city of bloodshed!
I too will make the pile great.
10 Pile up the wood, light the fire,
boil the meat through,
stir in the spices,[e]
and let the bones burn.
11 Then set the empty pot on the coals,
so that it grows hot and its copper glows,
its impurity melts within it,
and its corrosion is consumed.
12 It has exhausted my efforts;[f]
its heavy corrosion will not leave it.
Let its corrosion go into the fire!
13 Your uncleanness is lewdness. I sought to make you clean, yet clean of your impurity you would not be; and clean you will not be again till I have brought my fury on you to rest.
14 I, Yahweh, have spoken. It will happen, and I will act. I will not hold back or show pity or change my mind. They will sentence you according to your conduct and your actions, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"
15 The word of Yahweh came to me: 16 "Son of man, I am about to take from you with a single blow the delight of your eyes. Yet you must not mourn or weep or let your tears flow. 17 Sigh, but silently; hold no mourning rites for the dead. Wrap your turban on and lace your sandals onto your feet. Leave your mustache uncovered, and do not eat the bread men bring to mourners."[g] 18 I spoke to the people at dawn; at dusk my wife died. And at dawn I did what I had been ordered to do. 19 Then the people said to me, "Won't you explain to us what these actions of yours have to do with us?" 20 I said to them,

“The word of Yahweh came to me: 21 ‘Say to the house of Israel, “This
is what the Lord Yahweh says: I am about to profane my sanctuary,
the pride of your strength, the delight of your eyes, and the longing
of your soul. The sons and daughters you left behind will fall by the
sword. 22 You will do as I have done: you will not cover your upper
lip or eat the bread of mourners. 23 Your turbans will remain on your
heads and your sandals on your feet. You will not mourn or weep, but
you will waste away because of your guilt and groan to one another.
24 Ezekiel will be a sign to you; you will do everything he has done.
When this happens, you will know that I am the Lord Yahweh.”’
25 “And you, son of man—on the day when I take away their fortress,
their glorious joy, what delights their eyes and what their souls long
for, their sons and their daughters— 26 on that day a fugitive will come
to you to bring the news to your ears. 27 On that day your mouth will
be opened to the fugitive; you will speak and no longer be mute. So
you will be a sign to them, and they will know that I am Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (24:1) Hebrew: “in the tenth month, on the tenth of the month,” counting from the spring new year; this was the month later called Tevet, in January 588 BC by the usual reckoning (2 Kgs 25:1).
- b (24:5) Or “logs”; compare v. 10.
- c (24:6) Or “rust” or “scum”; the meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; also in vv. 11–12.
- d (24:6) That is, no portion is set aside to be spared.
- e (24:10) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; others render “pour out the broth.”
- f (24:12) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- g (24:17) Hebrew: “the bread of men”; many scholars, with a slight change, read “the bread of mourners”; also in v. 22.

Chapter 25

1 The word of Yahweh came to me: 2 “Son of man, turn your
face toward the Ammonites[a] and prophesy against them. 3 Tell the
Ammonites, ‘Hear the word of the Lord Yahweh. The Lord Yahweh
says this: You said “Ha!” over my sanctuary when it was desecrated,
over the land of Israel when it was ruined, and over the people of
Judah when they went into exile. 4 so look, I am giving you to the

sons of the east to own. They will set their camps in you and place their dwellings among you; they will be the ones to eat your fruit and drink your milk. 5 Rabbah I will turn into a grazing ground for camels, and Ammon's towns into a fold for sheep. And you will know that I am Yahweh. 6 For this is what the Lord Yahweh says: Because you clapped your hands and stamped your feet and rejoiced with all the contempt of your heart against the land of Israel, 7 therefore I have stretched out my hand against you and will give you as plunder to the nations. I will cut you off from the peoples and wipe you out from the countries; I will destroy you. Then you will know that I am Yahweh.'
8 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says: Because Moab and Seir[b] said, 'Look, the house of Judah is like all the other nations,' 9 therefore I am going to lay open the flank of Moab, stripping it of its towns, its frontier towns, the glory of the land—Beth-jeshimoth, Baal-meon, and Kiriathaim.[c] 10 Together with Ammon I will give it to the sons of the east to own, that Ammon may not be remembered among the nations. 11 And I will carry out judgments on Moab. Then they will know that I am Yahweh.
12 "The Lord Yahweh says this: Since Edom took vengeance on Judah's house and became deeply guilty by avenging itself on them, 13 therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: I will stretch out my hand against Edom and cut off from it both people and animals. I will make it a ruin; from Teman to Dedan[d] they will fall by the sword. 14 I will take my vengeance on Edom by the hand of my people Israel, and they will deal with Edom according to my anger and my fury. Then they will know my vengeance, declares the Lord Yahweh.
15 "The Lord Yahweh says this: The Philistines have acted in revenge and taken vengeance with malice in their hearts, aiming to destroy with never-ending hatred. 16 therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh says: I am going to stretch out my hand against the Philistines. I will cut off the Cherethites[e] and destroy the rest of the seacoast. 17 I will take terrible vengeance on them, punishing them in fury. Then they will know that I am Yahweh, when I take my vengeance on them."

Notes

- a (25:2) The Ammonites lived east of the Jordan; their capital was Rabbah (modern Amman).
- b (25:8) Seir is the mountain region of Edom. The Greek lacks “and Seir.”
- c (25:9) Beth-jeshimoth means “house of the wastelands”; Baal-meon, “lord of the dwelling”; Kiriathaim, “double city.”
- d (25:13) Teman was a region of Edom; Dedan was an Arabian oasis to the southeast.
- e (25:16) The Cherethites were a people associated with the Philistines, perhaps from Crete; the name plays on the verb “cut off” (karath).

Chapter 26

1 It was in the eleventh year, on the first of the month,[a] that Yahweh’s
word came to me: 2 “Son of man, since Tyre[b] has said about Jerusalem,
‘Ha! She that was the door of the peoples is shattered; she has been
flung open to me. Now that she is wasted, I will grow full,’ 3 the Lord
Yahweh says this: Look, I am coming at you, Tyre. Many nations I
will bring up against you, as the sea heaves up its breakers. 4 They
will demolish the walls of Tyre and knock down her towers. I will
sweep the dust off her and turn her into a bare rock. 5 She will become
a place in the middle of the sea for spreading out fishing nets, for I
have spoken, declares the Lord Yahweh. She will become plunder for
the nations, 6 and her daughters[c] on the mainland will be killed by the
sword. Then they will know that I am Yahweh.
7 “For the Lord Yahweh says this: Look, out of the north I am bringing
Nebuchadrezzar[d] of Babylon against Tyre, king of kings, with horse
and chariot, cavalry and a vast mob of troops. 8 He will kill your
daughters on the mainland with the sword. He will build a siege wall
against you, heap up a ramp against you, and raise a wall of shields
against you. 9 His battering rams he will set against your walls, and
your towers he will tear down with his iron tools. 10 So countless are
his horses that their dust will bury you. At the din of cavalry, wheels,
and chariots your walls will quake, when he comes in at your gates
as men come into a city broken open. 11 His horses’ hoofs will tread
every street of yours. Your people he will slay with the sword, and
your strong pillars will crash down to the earth. 12 Your riches will
be seized and your goods carried off as plunder. Your walls will be
pulled down and your pleasant houses wrecked; your stones, your

timbers, and your rubble will be dumped into the sea. 13 I will hush
the clamor of your songs; the music of your lyres will never sound
again. 14 I will make you a bare rock; you will be a place for spreading
nets. You will never be rebuilt, for I, Yahweh, have spoken, declares
the Lord Yahweh.
15 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says to Tyre: Will not the coast-
lands shake at the sound of your fall, when the wounded groan and
slaughter is done within you?
16 Then all the rulers of the coast will come down from their seats,
take off their robes, and remove their embroidered clothing. They will
dress themselves in terror and sit on the ground, shaking continually
and horrified over you.
17 They will raise a dirge for you and say to you:
'Ah, how you are lost,
you who were peopled from the seas,
the city held in honor,
strong upon the sea,
she and those who dwelt in her,
who laid their dread
on all her inhabitants!
18 Now the islands shake
on the day you fall;
the islands out in the sea
are terrified at your departure.'
19 "This is what the Lord Yahweh says: When I turn you into a ruined
city, like cities where nobody lives any more, when I raise the ocean
depths over you and the mighty waters cover you, 20 then I will bring
you down with those who go down to the pit,[e] to the people of long
ago. I will make you live in the land below, among ancient ruins, with
those who go down to the pit, so that you will not be inhabited or
take your place[f] in the land of the living. 21 I will make you a horror,
and you will be no more. Though you are sought, you will never be
found again, declares the Lord Yahweh."

Notes

- a (26:1) The month is not given in the Hebrew or the Greek. The eleventh year of Jehoiachin's exile was 587/586 BC, the year Jerusalem fell (v. 2).
- b (26:2) Tyre means "rock." It was the great Phoenician port, built largely on an island off the coast of modern Lebanon.
- c (26:6) That is, its dependent settlements; also in v. 8.
- d (26:7) Hebrew Nebuchadrezzar, a form closer to the Babylonian Nabu-kudurri-usur, "Nabu, protect my heir." His siege of Tyre lasted thirteen years (compare 29:18).
- e (26:20) That is, the realm of the dead.
- f (26:20) So the Greek ("nor stand"); the Hebrew has "and I will give glory."

Chapter 27

1 The word of Yahweh came to me:
2 "As for you, son of man, take up a lament over Tyre.
3 Say to Tyre, who sits at the gateways of the sea, merchant of the peoples to many coastlands, 'This is what the Lord Yahweh says:
Tyre, you have said,
"I am perfect in beauty."
4 Your borders were in the heart of the seas;
your builders perfected your beauty.
5 They fashioned all your planks
of juniper from Senir;[a]
they took a cedar from Lebanon
to make a mast for you.
6 They made your oars
from the oaks of Bashan;
they made your benches out of ivory
set in cypress[b] from the shores of Kittim.[c]
7 Your sail was of Egypt's embroidered linen,
spread out to be your ensign;
your canopy was violet and purple
from the shores of Elishah.[d]
8 The people of Sidon and Arvad[e] were your rowers;
your skilled men, Tyre, were aboard as your sailors.
9 Gebal's[f] elders and its experts were in you,
mending your leaks.

Every seagoing ship and its crews
came to you to deal in your wares.
10 "'Persia, Lud and Put[g] served in your army as your soldiers. They
hung their shields and helmets inside you; they gave you your glory.
11 Men of Arvad and your army were on your walls all around, and
men of Gammad[h] were in your towers. They hung their shields on
your walls all around; they perfected your beauty.
12 "'Tarshish[i] traded with you because of your great abundance of
every kind of wealth; for your wares they gave silver, iron, tin, and
lead.
13 Javan,[j] Tubal, and Meshech[k] were your dealers; for your wares they
paid in human lives and in bronze utensils.
14 From Beth-togarmah[l] they gave horses, war horses, and mules for
your wares.
15 The people of Dedan[m] traded with you; many coastlands were your
markets. They paid you with ivory tusks and ebony.
16 Aram[n] traded with you because of your many products; for your
wares they gave turquoise, purple, embroidered work, fine linen,
coral, and rubies.
17 Judah and the land of Israel traded with you; for your merchandise
they gave wheat from Minnith, millet,[o] honey, oil, and balm.
18 Damascus traded with you because of your many products and your
great abundance of every kind of wealth, with wine from Helbon and
wool from Zahar.[p]
19 Vedan and Javan from Uzal[q] gave wrought iron, cassia, and calamus
for your wares.
20 Dedan traded with you in saddlecloths for riding.
21 Arabia and all the princes of Kedar[r] were your customers; in lambs,
rams, and goats they traded with you.
22 The merchants of Sheba and Raamah[s] traded with you; for your
wares they gave the finest of all spices, every kind of precious stone,
and gold.
23 Haran, Canneh, Eden, the merchants of Sheba, Asshur, and Chilmad[t]
traded with you.

24 They traded with you in choice garments, in cloaks of blue and
embroidered work, and in carpets of many colors, bound with twisted
cords, in your marketplace.
25 Ships of Tarshish transported your goods.
And so you were full and heavily laden
in the middle of the seas.
26 "'Your rowers have brought you
out into the vast waters.
The east wind has shattered you
in the heart of the seas.
27 Your riches, your goods, your trade,
your sailors and your pilots,
your ship-menders and your merchants,
and all your soldiers within you,
together with the whole crowd in your midst,
will go down into the depths of the sea
the day you are wrecked.
28 At the sound of your sailors' cry
the open lands[u] will shake.
29 All who handle the oar
will come down from their ships;
the seamen and all the sailors of the sea
will stand on the shore.
30 Over you they will shout aloud
and wail with bitter cries;
dust they will toss on their heads,
and in ashes they will wallow.
31 They will shave their heads for you
and put on sackcloth;
they will weep over you in bitterness of soul,
with bitter mourning.[v]
32 In their wailing they will take up a lament for you
and chant over you:
"Who was like Tyre,
like her now silenced[w] in the midst of the sea?"

33 When your goods were unloaded from the seas,
you filled many nations;
by your enormous wealth and trade
you made earth's kings rich.
34 Now you are shattered by the seas,
in the depths of the waters;
your merchandise and all your company
have sunk with you.
35 All who live on the coasts
are shocked by you;
their kings bristle with fear;
their faces are twisted.
36 The merchants among the peoples hiss at you;
you have become a terror,
and you will be no more forever.'"

Notes

- a (27:5) Senir is another name for Mount Hermon (Deut 3:9).
- b (27:6) Hebrew bath-ashurim, traditionally "daughter of Assyrians"; with a different division of the letters, "in cypress" (bitashurim).
- c (27:6) Kittim is Cyprus, named after the city of Kition; the term was later used of western coastlands generally.
- d (27:7) Elishah is probably Alashiya, an ancient name for Cyprus or part of it.
- e (27:8) Arvad was a Phoenician island city north of Tyre.
- f (27:9) Gebal is Byblos, a Phoenician port north of Sidon.
- g (27:10) Lud is probably Lydia in Asia Minor; Put is probably Libya.
- h (27:11) The identity of Gammad is unknown; the Greek has "guards."
- i (27:12) Tarshish was a distant western port, probably in Spain (Tartessus); the Greek has "Carthaginians."
- j (27:13) Javan is Greece (Ionia).
- k (27:13) Tubal and Meshech were peoples of central Asia Minor (compare 38:2).
- l (27:14) Beth-togarmah was a region probably in eastern Asia Minor (Armenia).
- m (27:15) So the main Hebrew text; the Greek has "Rhodians," reflecting a reading "Rodan."
- n (27:16) Some ancient witnesses read "Edom"; in Hebrew the two names differ by one similar letter.
- o (27:17) The meaning of the Hebrew word rendered "millet" (pannag) is uncertain.
- p (27:18) Or "white wool."

- q (27:19) The Hebrew of v. 19 is uncertain; “from Uzal” may instead be read as part of the list of goods.
- r (27:21) Kedar was a tribe of the Arabian desert.
- s (27:22) Sheba and Raamah were peoples of southern Arabia.
- t (27:23) Chilmad is unidentified; the other names are trading centers of Mesopotamia and Arabia.
- u (27:28) Or “the pasturelands”; the meaning is uncertain.
- v (27:31) Verse 31 is not found in the Greek.
- w (27:32) The Hebrew word is uncertain; some read “like a ruin” or “like her destroyed one.”

Chapter 28

1 Yahweh’s word came to me:
2 “Son of man, tell the ruler of Tyre, ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: /
Your heart has grown lofty, / and you have said, “A god am I; / in the seat of gods I sit, / in the heart of the seas.” / Yet you are a mortal, not a god, / though you have made your mind like the mind of a god.
3 Look, you are wiser than Danel;[a] / no secret is too dark for you.
4 By your wisdom and your understanding / you have gained wealth for yourself, / and gold and silver you have amassed / in your treasure houses.
5 By your great skill in trade / you have multiplied your wealth, / and your heart has grown lofty / because of your wealth.
6 “‘So the Lord Yahweh says this: / Since you have made your mind / like the mind of a god,
7 look, I am bringing foreigners against you, / the most ruthless of nations. / They will bare their swords against the beauty your wisdom made / and defile your splendor.
8 Down to the pit[b] they will send you, / and you will die the death of the slain / in the heart of the seas.
9 Before the one who slays you,
will you go on saying, “I am a god”?
You will be a mortal, not a god,
in the grip of those who pierce you.
10 You will die the death of the uncircumcised[c] / at the hand of foreigners. / For I have spoken, declares the Lord Yahweh.’”

11 Yahweh's word came to me:
12 "Son of man, raise a dirge over the king of Tyre and say to him,
'The Lord Yahweh says this: / You were the seal of perfection,[d] / full
of wisdom and flawless in beauty.
13 In Eden, God's garden, you lived;
gems of every kind adorned you:
carnelian, chrysolite, and moonstone,
beryl, onyx, and jasper,
lapis lazuli, turquoise, and emerald;[e]
and your settings and mountings were worked in gold.
On the day you were created they were made ready.
14 You were an anointed cherub, a guardian;[f] / I placed you there. / On
God's holy mountain you were; / among stones of fire you walked
about.
15 Blameless you were in your ways / from the day you were created, /
until wrong was discovered in you.
16 Through the abundance of your trade / your insides filled with
violence, / and you sinned. / So I banished you as profane from God's
mountain, / and I destroyed you, guardian cherub, / from among the
stones of fire.
17 Your heart grew lofty because of your beauty; / you ruined your
wisdom for the sake of your splendor. / I hurled you to the earth; /
before kings I set you out, / for them to feast their eyes on you.
18 By your many wrongs,
by your dishonest dealing,
you made your sanctuaries unclean.
So I brought out a fire from inside you;
it consumed you,
and I reduced you to ashes on the earth
in full view of everyone watching you.
19 All among the peoples who knew you / are appalled at you. / You
have become a terror, / and you will be no more forever.'"
20 Yahweh's word came to me: 21 "Son of man, set your face toward
Sidon[g] and prophesy against her. 22 Say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this:
Look, I am coming against you, Sidon, and I will win glory in your

midst. They will know that I am Yahweh when I carry out judgments on her and show myself holy in her. 23 I will send plague into her and blood into her streets. The slain will fall within her, by the sword that comes against her from every side. And they will know that I am Yahweh. 24 "'No more will the house of Israel have a briar that pricks or a thorn that wounds from any of the neighbors around them who treat them with contempt. And they will know that I am the Lord Yahweh.

25 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: When I gather Israel's house from the peoples among whom they are scattered, and show myself holy through them before the nations' eyes, then they will live on their own soil, which I gave to my servant Jacob. 26 They will live on it in security, building houses and planting vineyards; in security they will live, when I carry out judgments on all their neighbors who treat them with contempt. And they will know that I am Yahweh their God.'"

Notes

- a (28:3) Hebrew Danel; see the note at 14:14.
- b (28:8) That is, the realm of the dead.
- c (28:10) That is, a shameful death without honorable burial; the phrase is used of the Phoenicians, who practiced circumcision, as a mark of disgrace.
- d (28:12) The Hebrew phrase is obscure; it may mean "sealer of proportion," that is, the model of a perfect design. The Greek has "a seal of likeness."
- e (28:13) The identification of many of these stones is uncertain. The Hebrew lists nine stones, all found among the twelve on the high priest's breastpiece (Exodus 28:17–20). The Greek lists all twelve of the breastpiece stones, adds silver and gold, and has a different final clause.
- f (28:14) Or "You were with an anointed guardian cherub." The Hebrew pronoun "you" has an unusual feminine form; the Greek reads "with the cherub" and lacks "anointed."
- g (28:21) Sidon, about 25 miles (40 kilometers) north of Tyre, was the other great Phoenician city.

Chapter 29

1 In the tenth year, on the twelfth day of the tenth month (in December–January),[a] Yahweh's word came to me: 2 "Son of man, set your face against Pharaoh king of Egypt, and prophesy against him

and against all Egypt. 3 Speak and say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: /
Look, I am coming against you, / Pharaoh, king of Egypt, / the great
monster[b] sprawled / in the midst of his Nile channels, / who says, "My
Nile is mine; / I made it for myself." 4 I will set hooks in your jaws /
and cause the fish of your channels to stick to your scales. / Out of
the middle of your channels I will drag you, / together with every
fish of your channels / that clings to your scales. 5 I will fling you into
the wilderness, / you and all the fish of your streams. / On the open
field you will fall; / no one will gather you up or collect you. / To
the beasts of the earth and the birds of the sky / I have given you as
food. 6 Then all who live in Egypt will know / that I am Yahweh, /
because they have been a staff of reed / to the house of Israel. 7 When
they took hold of you by the hand,[c] you splintered / and tore open
every shoulder of theirs; / when they leaned their weight on you, you
snapped, / and made every one of their hips give way.[d]
8 "'So the Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am bringing a sword upon
you, and I will cut off from you human and beast. 9 Egypt will become
a desolate wasteland, and they will know that I am Yahweh. He
claimed, "The Nile belongs to me; I created it," 10 look, I am coming
against you and against your streams. I will turn Egypt's land into an
utter ruin, a desolation, from Migdol to Syene[e] and as far as the border
of Cush.[f] 11 No human foot will cross it, and no animal's foot will cross
it; for forty years it will be uninhabited. 12 I will make Egypt's land a
desolation among desolate lands, and its cities will lie desolate among
ruined cities for forty years. I will scatter the Egyptians among the
nations and disperse them through the lands.
13 "'Yet the Lord Yahweh says this: At the end of forty years I will
gather the Egyptians from the peoples where they were scattered. 14
I will turn back Egypt's captivity and return them to Pathros,[g] their
homeland, and they will be a lowly kingdom there. 15 It will be the
lowliest of the kingdoms and will never again lift itself above the
nations. I will make them so few that they will not rule over the
nations. 16 Never again will Egypt be the trust of Israel's house; instead
it will be a reminder of their guilt in turning to them for help. And
they will know that I am the Lord Yahweh.'"

17 In the twenty-seventh year, on the first day of the first month
(in March–April),[h] Yahweh's word came to me: 18 "Son of man, Neb-
uchadrezzar king of Babylon drove his army to hard labor against
Tyre. Every head was rubbed bald and every shoulder rubbed raw.
Yet from Tyre neither he nor his army got any wages for the labor he
spent on it. 19 So the Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am giving Egypt's
land to Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon. He will carry off its riches,[i]
take its spoil, and seize its plunder, and that will be the wages for
his army. 20 As payment for the work he labored at, I have given him
Egypt's land, because they did it for me, declares the Lord Yahweh.
21 "On that day I will make a horn[j] sprout for Israel's house, and I will
give you an open mouth among them. And they will know that I am
Yahweh."

Notes

- a (29:1) Hebrew "in the tenth month, on the twelfth of the month." On the spring-start calendar used in Ezekiel, the tenth month is Tevet; the date falls in January 587 BC. The Greek reads "the twelfth year … on the first of the month."
- b (29:3) Hebrew tannim, a variant of tannin, "sea monster" or "dragon"; here a picture of the crocodile.
- c (29:7) So the Hebrew margin and the Greek; the Hebrew text has "by your palm."
- d (29:7) Probable reading; compare the Greek "crushed the loins of them all." The Hebrew reads "made all their hips stand."
- e (29:10) Migdol was in the northeast of Egypt and Syene (modern Aswan) in the far south; the phrase means "from one end of Egypt to the other."
- f (29:10) That is, the upper Nile region (Nubia, in modern Sudan).
- g (29:14) That is, Upper (southern) Egypt.
- h (29:17) Hebrew "in the first, on the first of the month." On the spring-start calendar the first month is Nisan; the date falls in April 571 BC, the latest dated oracle in the book.
- i (29:19) Or "its multitude."
- j (29:21) The horn is a symbol of strength.

Chapter 30

1 Yahweh's word came to me:
2 "Son of man, prophesy and say, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: / Howl,
"Alas for the day!"
3 For the day is near, / the day of Yahweh is near, / a day of cloud, / a
time of doom for the nations.

4 A sword will come against Egypt, / and anguish will seize Cush, /
when the slain fall in Egypt, / when her wealth is carried away / and
her foundations torn down.
5 Cush, Put, and Lud, all the mixed peoples,[a] Cub,[b] and the people of
the allied land[c] will fall by the sword with them.
6 "'Yahweh says this:
Egypt's supporters will fall,
and her proud strength will come down.
From Migdol all the way to Syene
the sword will cut them down within her,
declares the Lord Yahweh.
7 They will be desolate / among desolate lands, / and its cities will lie /
among ruined cities.
8 They will know that I am Yahweh / when I set fire to Egypt / and all
her helpers are crushed.
9 "'On that day messengers will go out from me in ships to terrify
unsuspecting Cush. Anguish will take hold of them on Egypt's day—
for look, it is coming!
10 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: / I will put an end to Egypt's horde /
by the hand of Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon.
11 He and his army with him, / the cruelest of all the nations, / will
be brought to devastate the country. / They will draw their swords
against Egypt / and cover the land with dead bodies.
12 I will turn the Nile channels into dry ground / and sell the land
into the hands of evil men. / By the hand of foreigners I will make
desolate / the land and everything in it. / I, Yahweh, have spoken.
13 "'The Lord Yahweh says this:
I will wipe out the idols
and make an end of Memphis's worthless gods.[d]
No prince will rise again
from Egypt's land,
and I will put fear in Egypt's land.
14 I will make Pathros desolate, / set fire to Zoan,[e] / and carry out
judgments on Thebes.[f]

15 I will pour out my fury on Pelusium,[g] / Egypt's stronghold, / and
cut off the horde of Thebes.
16 I will set Egypt ablaze;
Pelusium will writhe in pain,
Thebes will be split open,
and Memphis will meet foes in broad day.[h]
17 On's[i] youths and those of Pi-beseth[j]
will be cut down by the sword,
and the towns themselves[k] will go into captivity.
18 In Tehaphnehes[l] the daylight will be blocked[m] / when I smash the
yoke bars of Egypt there, / and her arrogant power ends within her. /
Clouds will cover her, / and her daughters will be taken captive.
19 So I will carry out judgments on Egypt, / and they will know that I
am Yahweh.'"
20 In the eleventh year, on the seventh day of the first month (in
March–April),[n] Yahweh's word came to me: 21 "Son of man, I have
broken the arm of Pharaoh king of Egypt. Look, it has not been bound
up for healing; no bandage has been put on to strengthen it so that it
can grasp a sword. 22 So the Lord Yahweh says this: Watch out, I am
against Pharaoh king of Egypt. I will break both his arms, the healthy
one and the one already broken, and knock the sword out of his
grasp. 23 I will scatter the Egyptians among the nations and disperse
them through the lands. 24 I will strengthen the arms of Babylon's
king and put my sword into his hand, but Pharaoh's arms I will
smash, and Pharaoh will moan in front of the king like a man who is
fatally wounded. 25 I will strengthen the arms of Babylon's king, while
Pharaoh's arms will drop. They will know that I am Yahweh when I
put my sword into the hand of Babylon's king and he stretches it out
against Egypt's land. 26 I will scatter the Egyptians among the nations
and disperse them through the lands. And they will know that I am
Yahweh."

Notes

- a (30:5) Or "all Arabia"; the Hebrew consonants can be read either way. The Greek list differs (it has "Persians, and Cretans, and Lydians, and Libyans, and all the mixed multitude").

- b (30:5) Cub is otherwise unknown; many scholars read Lub, "Libya."
- c (30:5) Hebrew "the children of the land of the covenant"; the Greek has "the children of my covenant." The phrase may refer to allies of Egypt, or possibly to Judeans living in Egypt.
- d (30:13) Hebrew Noph, the ancient capital of Lower Egypt, near modern Cairo; also in v. 16. Instead of "the idols," the Greek has "the nobles."
- e (30:14) Zoan, called Tanis by the Greeks, was in the northeastern Nile delta.
- f (30:14) Hebrew No, the great city of Upper Egypt, modern Luxor; also in vv. 15–16.
- g (30:15) Hebrew Sin; also in v. 16. Pelusium was a frontier fortress in the northeastern delta. The Greek has "Sais" here and "Syene" in v. 16.
- h (30:16) The meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain; the Greek reads "and waters will be poured out."
- i (30:17) Hebrew Aven ("wickedness"), a play on On, the city called Heliopolis, "city of the sun," northeast of modern Cairo.
- j (30:17) Pi-beseth, called Bubastis by the Greeks, was in the eastern delta.
- k (30:17) Hebrew "they"; the pronoun is feminine and probably refers to the towns. The Greek has "the women."
- l (30:18) Tehaphnehes (also spelled Tahpanhes) is Daphnae, a fortress in the northeastern delta (compare Jeremiah 43:7–9).
- m (30:18) So the Greek and some ancient witnesses; the main Hebrew text has "will hold back."
- n (30:20) Hebrew "in the first, on the seventh of the month." On the spring-start calendar the first month is Nisan; the date falls in April 587 BC.

Chapter 31

1 In the eleventh year, on the first day of the third month (in May–June),[a] Yahweh's word came to me: 2 "Son of man, say to Pharaoh king of Egypt and to his horde: / 'Whom are you like in your greatness? 3 Consider Assyria,[b] a cedar in Lebanon, / with lovely boughs and shade like a forest's, / towering in height, / its crown up among the clouds.[c] 4 The waters made it great; / the deep made it tall, / sending its streams / all around the place it was planted / and sending its channels / to all the trees of the field. 5 So it grew taller / than all the trees of the field; / its boughs multiplied / and its branches grew long / from the abundant water as it spread out. 6 In its boughs / every bird of the sky made its nest; / under its branches / every beast of the field gave birth; / and in its shade / all the great nations lived. 7 It was beautiful in its greatness, / in the length of its limbs, / for its roots went down / to abundant waters. 8 The cedars in God's garden /

could not rival it; / the junipers were nothing like its boughs, / and the plane trees[d] were nothing / to compare with its branches. / No tree in God's garden / matched it in beauty. 9 I made it beautiful / with its mass of limbs, / and all the trees of Eden, / those in God's garden, envied it.

10 "'So the Lord Yahweh says this: Because it[e] towered high and set its crown among the clouds, and its heart grew proud of its height, 11 I handed it over to the mightiest ruler of the nations, who will surely deal with it as its wickedness deserves. I have driven it out. 12 Foreigners, the most ruthless of nations, cut it down and left it lying. On the mountains and in every valley its limbs have fallen; its branches lie broken in every ravine of the land. All the peoples of the earth came out from its shade and left it. 13 On its fallen trunk all the birds of the sky settle, / and among its branches / all the beasts of the field take shelter. 14 This is so that no trees by the waters may tower to such a height or set their crowns among the clouds, and that no well-watered trees[f] may rise to equal them. For every one of them is given over to death, to the world below, among mortals, with those who descend to the pit.

15 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: On the day it went down to Sheol[g] I made the deep mourn for it and covered it over;[h] I held back its streams, and the great waters were checked. For its sake I dressed Lebanon in mourning, and every tree of the field wilted over it. 16 At the sound of its fall I made the nations quake, when I cast it down to Sheol with those who descend to the pit. And all Eden's trees, the choicest and best of Lebanon, all that drink water, were comforted in the world below. 17 They too went down with it to Sheol, to those slain by the sword—those who had been its arm,[i] who lived in its shade among the nations. 18 "'Whom are you like, then, in glory and greatness among the trees of Eden? Yet you too will be brought down with the trees of Eden to the world below. Among the uncircumcised you will lie, with the sword's slain. This is Pharaoh and all his horde, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (31:1) Hebrew “in the third, on the first of the month.” On the spring-start calendar the third month is Sivan; the date falls in June 587 BC.
- b (31:3) Some scholars, reading one letter differently, find here not “Assyria” but “a cypress” (te’ashshur), so that the cedar stands for Pharaoh himself. The Greek has “the Assyrian was a cypress in Lebanon.”
- c (31:3) So the Greek; the Hebrew word may mean “thick foliage”; also in vv. 10 and 14.
- d (31:8) The identification of these trees is uncertain.
- e (31:10) Hebrew “you”; the Hebrew shifts between “you” and “it.”
- f (31:14) Hebrew “all that drink water.”
- g (31:15) Sheol is the realm of the dead; also in vv. 16–17.
- h (31:15) Or “I closed the deep over it.” The Hebrew is difficult; the Greek has simply “the deep mourned for him.”
- i (31:17) The Hebrew is difficult; the Greek reads “his seed.”

Chapter 32

1 In the twelfth year, on the first day of the twelfth month (in February–March),[a] Yahweh’s word came to me:
2 “Son of man, raise a dirge over Pharaoh king of Egypt and say to him: / ‘Among the nations you likened yourself to a young lion, / but you are like a monster in the seas; / you burst out in your rivers, / churned the waters with your feet, / and fouled their streams.
3 “‘The Lord Yahweh says this: / I will cast my net over you / with a throng of many peoples, / and they will haul you up in my dragnet.
4 I will fling you onto the land; / on the open field I will hurl you down. / I will make every bird of the sky settle on you / and let the beasts of all the earth gorge themselves on you.
5 I will spread your flesh on the mountains / and fill the valleys with your carcass.[b]
6 I will water the land with what flows from you,
with your blood up to the mountains,
and the gullies will be full of you.
7 When I put out your light, I will veil the heavens
and blacken their stars;
a cloud will hide the sun,
and the moon will give no light.

8 Every shining light in the heavens / I will darken over you, / and I
will set darkness over your land, / declares the Lord Yahweh.
9 "'I will trouble the hearts of many peoples / when I bring your
shattering[c] among the nations, / to lands you have not known.
10 I will horrify many peoples because of you, / and their kings will
be shaken with dread over you / when I wave my sword in front of
them. / Every one of them will shake each moment for his own life /
on the day you fall.
11 "'For the Lord Yahweh says this: / The sword of Babylon's king /
will come upon you.
12 By the swords of warriors / I will fell your horde— / the most ruthless
of nations, every one. / They will ravage Egypt's pride, / and all her
horde will be wiped out.
13 I will destroy all her cattle / from beside the abundant waters. /
No human foot will churn them again, / and no hoof of beast will
churn them.
14 Then I will let their waters settle / and make their streams flow like
oil, / declares the Lord Yahweh.
15 When I make Egypt's land a desolation,
a land stripped of all that filled it,
when I strike down every one of its inhabitants,
then they will know that I am Yahweh.
16 This is a dirge, and they will chant it; / the daughters of the nations
will chant it. / Over Egypt and over all her horde they will chant it, /
declares the Lord Yahweh.'"
17 In the twelfth year, on the fifteenth day of the month,[d] Yahweh's
word came to me: 18 "Son of man, mourn for the mob of Egypt, and
send her down, along with the daughters of the powerful nations, into
the underworld, to join those who descend into the pit. 19 'Are you
lovelier than anyone? Down with you; lie among the uncircumcised!'[e]
20 They will fall among those slain by the sword. A sword has been
handed over; drag her away with all her hordes.[f] 21 From inside Sheol
the strongest of the mighty ones will speak to him and to his allies:
'They have come down and lie motionless, the uncircumcised, killed
by the sword.'

22 “Assyria is there with her whole army, her tombs surrounding him,[g]
all of them killed, struck down by the sword. 23 Her graves are set in
the remotest depths of the pit, and her company lies around her grave,
all of them slain, fallen by the sword, they who once spread terror
in the land of the living. 24 “Elam[h] is there with all her horde around
her grave, all of them slain, fallen by the sword, who went down
uncircumcised to the world below, they who once spread terror in the
land of the living. Now they bear their disgrace with those who go
down to the pit. 25 Among the slain they have made a bed for her with
all her horde, their graves all around her, all of them uncircumcised,
slain by the sword. Because terror of them was spread in the land of
the living, they bear their disgrace with those who go down to the pit;
she is laid among the slain. 26 “Meshech and Tubal[i] are there with all
their multitudes; their tombs surround them. All are uncircumcised
and run through with the sword, since they spread dread across the
land of the living. 27 They do not lie beside the other fallen warriors,
the uncircumcised,[j] who went down to Sheol equipped for war, with
their swords laid under their heads and their shields[k] over their bones,
since these heroes spread dread across the land of the living. 28 And
you too will be broken among the uncircumcised and lie with those
slain by the sword. 29 “Edom is there, her kings and all her chiefs,
who for all their might are laid with those slain by the sword. With
the uncircumcised they lie, and with those who descend to the pit.
30 “The rulers of the north are there, every one of them, and all the
Sidonians, who went down in disgrace with the slain, though their
power had inspired terror. They lie uncircumcised beside those killed
by the sword and carry their shame together with those who descend
to the pit. 31 “Pharaoh will see them and be consoled over all his horde
—Pharaoh and all his army, slain by the sword, declares the Lord
Yahweh. 32 For I spread terror of him[l] in the land of the living, yet he
will be laid among the uncircumcised, with those slain by the sword
—Pharaoh and all his horde, declares the Lord Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (32:1) Hebrew “in the twelfth month, on the first of the month.” On the spring-start calendar the twelfth month is Adar; the date falls in March 585 BC. The Greek has “the tenth month.”
- b (32:5) Or “your heap of worms”; the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- c (32:9) So the Hebrew; the Greek reads “your captivity.”
- d (32:17) The Hebrew does not name the month. If the twelfth month of v. 1 is meant, the date is in March 585 BC. The Greek reads “in the first month” (Nisan, in March–April), which would place the oracle in April 586 BC.
- e (32:19) This verse is absent from the Greek, which has a differently arranged text in vv. 19–21.
- f (32:20) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- g (32:22) Hebrew “him”; the Hebrew shifts between masculine and feminine references to Assyria in vv. 22–23.
- h (32:24) Elam was a kingdom east of Babylon, in what is now southwestern Iran.
- i (32:26) On Meshech and Tubal see the note at 27:13.
- j (32:27) The Greek has “with the giants that fell of old,” perhaps reading a slightly different Hebrew word for “of the uncircumcised.”
- k (32:27) Probable reading; the Hebrew has “their iniquities.”
- l (32:32) So the Hebrew text and the Greek; the Hebrew margin has “my terror.”

Chapter 33

1 Yahweh’s word came to me: 2 “Son of man, speak to your people’s
children and tell them: Suppose I bring the sword against a land, and
the people of that land pick one man from their ranks and make him
their lookout. 3 He sees the sword coming against the land, sounds
the ram’s horn,[a] and warns the people. 4 Then if anyone hears the
horn’s blast and pays no heed, and the sword comes and takes him
away, his blood will be on his own head. 5 He heard the horn’s blast
and paid no heed; his blood is on himself. Had he heeded, he would
have saved his life. 6 But suppose the lookout sees the sword coming
and does not sound the horn, so the people are not warned, and the
sword comes and takes one of them. That person is taken away in his
guilt, but I will hold the lookout to account for his blood.
7 “As for you, son of man, I have made you a lookout for Israel’s house.
Whenever you hear a word from my mouth, warn them for me. 8 If I
tell the wicked person, ‘You wicked man, you are going to die,’ and
you do not speak out to turn him from his way, then that wicked
person will die for his guilt, but I will hold you accountable for his

blood. 9 But if you do warn the wicked to turn from his course, and
he does not turn from it, he will die in his guilt, but you will have
rescued your own life.
10 "And you, son of man, say to Israel's house: This is what you
keep saying: 'Our rebellions and our sins weigh on us, and we are
wasting away under them. How then can we live?' 11 Tell them: 'As
I live, declares the Lord Yahweh, I take no delight in the death of
the wicked, but rather in the wicked turning from his course and
living. Turn back, turn back from your evil ways! Why should you
die, house of Israel?' 12 "And you, son of man, say to your people: The
righteousness of a righteous person will not save him when he rebels,
and the wickedness of a wicked person will not make him stumble
when he turns away from it. A righteous person cannot live on the
strength of his righteousness when he sins. 13 If I tell the righteous
that he will surely live, and he trusts in his own righteousness and
does wrong, none of his righteous acts will be remembered; he will
die for the wrong he has done. 14 And if I tell the wicked, 'You will
surely die,' and he turns from his sin and does what is just and right
— 15 if the wicked man returns a pledge, pays back what he stole, and
walks in the statutes that give life, doing no wrong—he will surely
live; he will not die. 16 Not one sin of his will be remembered against
him. Justice and right are what he has done; he will surely live. 17 "Yet
your people's children say, 'The Lord's way is not fair,' when it is their
own way that is not fair. 18 When a righteous person turns from his
righteousness and does wrong, he will die for it. 19 And if the wicked
one leaves his wickedness behind and practices justice and right, by
these he will live. 20 Yet you say, 'The Lord's way is not fair.' House of
Israel, I will judge each of you by your ways."
21 In the twelfth year of our exile, on the fifth day of the tenth month (in
December–January),[b] someone who had fled from Jerusalem reached
me with the news: "The city is struck down!" 22 Now the evening
before the fugitive arrived, Yahweh's hand had come on me, and he
opened my mouth before the man reached me at dawn. My mouth
was opened, and I kept silent no longer.

23 Yahweh's word came to me: 24 "Son of man, those living in these
ruins on Israel's soil are saying, 'Abraham was only one man, yet he
took possession of the land. But we are numerous; to us the land is
surely handed over to hold.' 25 So tell them: 'The Lord Yahweh says
this: You eat meat with the blood in it, lift your eyes to your idols,
and shed blood. Should you then possess the land? 26 You lean on your
swords, you practice abominations, and every man of you defiles the
wife of his neighbor. Should you then possess the land?'[c] 27 "Tell them
this: 'The Lord Yahweh says: As surely as I live, those who are among
the ruins will die by the sword, anyone out in the open I will give to
the wild animals as food, and those in the fortresses and caves will
die of disease. 28 I will turn the land into a waste and a horror, and the
pride of its strength will cease. Israel's mountains will be so desolate
that no one will pass through them. 29 Then they will know that I am
Yahweh, when I turn the land into a waste and a horror for all the
abominations they have done.'
30 "As for you, son of man, your people's children are talking about you
by the walls and in the doorways of the houses. One says to another,
every man to his brother, 'Let us go and hear what word comes from
Yahweh.' 31 They come to you as people do, and sit before you as my
people, and they hear your words, but they do not act on them. With
their mouths they show much love,[d] but their hearts chase after their
own gain. 32 To them you are like a love song, sung by one with a
lovely voice who plays the instrument well. They hear your words,
but they do not act on them. 33 Yet when this comes—and it is coming!
—they will know that a prophet has been among them."

Notes

- a (33:3) Hebrew shofar, also in vv. 4–6.
- b (33:21) Hebrew "in the tenth month, on the fifth of the month." On the spring-start calendar the tenth month is Tevet; the date falls in January 585 BC, about five months after the city fell. The Greek has "in the tenth year … in the twelfth month," and some ancient witnesses have "the eleventh year."
- c (33:26) The Greek lacks most of vv. 25–26, from "You eat meat" to the end of v. 26.
- d (33:31) Or "they act out lust"; the Hebrew is uncertain. The Greek has "falsehood is in their mouth."

Chapter 34

1 Yahweh's word came to me: 2 "Son of man, prophesy against Israel's
shepherds. Prophesy, and say to them, to the shepherds: 'The Lord
Yahweh says this: Woe to Israel's shepherds, who have been tending
only themselves! Is it not the flock that shepherds ought to tend? 3 You
eat the fat,[a] you dress in the wool, you slaughter the fatlings, but the
flock you do not tend. 4 The weak you have not made strong, the sick
you have not healed, the injured you have not bandaged, the strays
you have not brought back, the lost you have not sought; with force
and harshness you have ruled them. 5 So they were scattered for lack
of a shepherd, and once scattered they became food for every wild
beast. 6 My sheep wandered over every mountain and every high hill;
across the whole face of the earth my sheep were scattered, with no
one searching or seeking for them.
7 "'So, you shepherds, hear Yahweh's word: 8 As I live, declares the
Lord Yahweh, because my sheep have become plunder, because my
sheep have become food for every wild beast for lack of a shepherd,
since my shepherds did not search for my sheep but tended them-
selves and not my flock— 9 therefore, you shepherds, hear Yahweh's
word. 10 The Lord Yahweh says: I am against the shepherds! I will take
my flock back from them and stop them from feeding the flock, so the
shepherds will no longer feed themselves. I will pull my sheep out of
their mouths, and the sheep will no longer be their food.
11 "'For the Lord Yahweh says this: Here I am; I myself will search for
my sheep and look after them. 12 Like a shepherd who goes looking for
his flock when his sheep are scattered around him, I will go looking
for my sheep. I will save them from all the places they were scattered
during a day of clouds and gloom. 13 I will bring them out from the
peoples, gather them from the lands, and bring them into their own
soil. I will pasture them on Israel's mountains, by the ravines, and in
every inhabited place in the land. 14 In good pasture I will feed them,
and on the lofty mountains of Israel their grazing ground will be.
There they will lie down in a good fold and feed on rich pasture on
Israel's mountains. 15 I myself will be the shepherd of my sheep, and I
myself will give them rest, declares the Lord Yahweh. 16 I will look for

the lost, return the strays, bandage the wounded and give strength to the weak; but the fat and the strong I will destroy.[b] I will tend them with justice.

17 "As for you, my flock, the Lord Yahweh says this: I will judge between one animal and another, between the rams and the male goats. 18 Is it not enough for you to feed on the best pasture? Must you also tread down with your feet whatever pasture is left? Or to drink clear water, that you must muddy the rest with your feet? 19 Must my sheep eat the ground your hooves have trodden and drink the water your hooves have fouled? 20 "'So the Lord Yahweh says this to them: Here I am; I myself will judge between the fat sheep and the lean. 21 Because you shove with flank and shoulder and butt all the weak ones with your horns until you have scattered them abroad, 22 I will save my flock; no longer will they be plunder. I will judge between one sheep and another. 23 Over them I will set up one shepherd, my servant David, to pasture them. He will feed them himself and be a shepherd to them. 24 I, Yahweh, will be their God, and my servant David will be prince among them. I, Yahweh, have spoken.

25 "'With them I will cut a covenant of peace and banish the wild beasts from the land, so that in the wilderness they can dwell in safety and in the woods they can sleep. 26 I will make them and the places around my hill a blessing.[c] I will send down the rain in its season; there will be showers of blessing. 27 The trees of the field will yield their fruit and the land its produce, and they will be secure on their own soil. They will know that I am Yahweh when I break the bars of their yoke and rescue them from the hand of those who enslaved them. 28 No longer will they be plunder for the nations, nor will the land's wild beasts devour them. They will live in safety, with no one to frighten them. 29 I will raise up for them a planting renowned for its yield,[d] and no longer will they be swept away by famine in the land or bear the scorn of the nations. 30 Then they will know that I, Yahweh their God, am with them, and that they, Israel's house, are my people, declares the Lord Yahweh. 31 You are my sheep, the flock that I feed; you are humans,[e] and I am your God, declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (34:3) So the Hebrew vowels; with different vowels, and the Greek, “the milk.”
- b (34:16) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “the strong I will guard,” reading a similar Hebrew word.
- c (34:26) Or “I will make them a blessing around my hill.” The Greek reads “I will settle them around my mountain.”
- d (34:29) Hebrew “a planting for a name”; the Greek has “a plant of peace.”
- e (34:31) Hebrew adam, “humankind,” the word in the title “son of man” (ben adam; see the note at 2:1). The Greek lacks “you are human.”

Chapter 35

1 Yahweh’s word came to me: 2 “Son of man, turn your face toward
Mount Seir[a] and prophesy against it. 3 Say to it: ‘The Lord Yahweh
says this: I am coming against you, Mount Seir; I will stretch out my
hand against you and make you a desolate waste. 4 Your towns I will
turn into ruins, and you yourself will become a desolation. Then you
will know that I am Yahweh. 5 “‘Because you nursed an age-old hatred
and handed Israel’s people over to the power of the sword at the time
of their disaster, the time of their final punishment, 6 therefore, as I
live, declares the Lord Yahweh, I will deliver you up to bloodshed,
and bloodshed will hound you. Since you did not hate bloodshed,
bloodshed will hound you.[b] 7 Mount Seir I will turn into a waste and a
horror, and from it I will cut off all who pass to and fro. 8 I will fill your
mountains with the dead; those killed by the sword will fall on your
hills, in your valleys and in all your gullies. 9 A desolation forever I
will make you, and your towns will not be inhabited.[c] Then you will
know that I am Yahweh. 10 “‘Because you said, “These two nations and
these two lands will be mine, and we will take possession of them”—
though Yahweh was there— 11 therefore, as surely as I live, declares the
Lord Yahweh, I will treat you with the same anger and jealousy that
you showed in your hatred toward them. I will reveal myself among
them[d] when I judge you. 12 Then you will know that I am Yahweh.
I have heard every insult you spoke against the mountains of Israel
when you said, “They are laid waste; they were given to us to devour.”
13 With your mouths you made yourselves great against me and piled
up your words against me. I heard it. 14 “‘The Lord Yahweh says this:
While the whole earth rejoices, I will make you a desolation. 15 As you

rejoiced over the inheritance of Israel's house because it was made desolate, so I will deal with you. A desolation you will be, Mount Seir, you and all Edom, every bit of it. Then they will know that I am Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (35:2) See the note at 25:8.
- b (35:6) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult; "blood" may also hint at Edom's name (compare Hebrew dam, "blood," and adom, "red").
- c (35:9) So the Hebrew margin; the Hebrew text may be read "will not return."
- d (35:11) The Greek has "to you."

Chapter 36

1 "And you, son of man, prophesy to Israel's mountains and say: 'Mountains of Israel, hear Yahweh's word. 2 The Lord Yahweh says this: Your enemy jeered over you, "Aha! Those age-old heights[a] are ours to hold now!" 3 So prophesy and say: The Lord Yahweh says this: Because they made you desolate and hounded you from every side, until the remaining nations owned you, and you have become the talk of gossiping tongues and the slander of the people, 4 therefore, mountains of Israel, listen to the word of the Lord Yahweh. To the mountains and hills, to the gullies and valleys, to the ruined wastes and abandoned cities that have been plundered and ridiculed by the other nations all around, the Lord Yahweh says this: 5 the Lord Yahweh says this: In the fire of my jealousy I have spoken against the rest of the nations and against all Edom, who with wholehearted glee and contempt claimed my land as their own possession, so as to drive out its pasture and plunder it.[b] 6 So prophesy concerning Israel's soil and tell the mountains and the hills, the ravines and the valleys: The Lord Yahweh says this: In my jealousy and my fury I speak, because you have endured the nations' scorn. 7 So the Lord Yahweh says this: I lift my hand and swear that the nations around you will themselves endure scorn.

8 "'But as for you, mountains of Israel, you will grow branches and produce fruit for my people Israel, because they will return home before long. 9 For see, I am for you; I will turn my face to you, and plowmen and sowers will work you. 10 I will multiply people upon

you, the whole house of Israel, all of it. The towns will be inhabited and the ruins rebuilt. 11 I will multiply on you both human and beast; they will increase and be fruitful. I will settle you as you were in former times and treat you better than at your beginning. Then you will know that I am Yahweh. 12 I will make people walk upon you, my people Israel. They will possess you, and you will be their inheritance; never again will you rob them of their children. 13 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: Because people say to you, "You devour human beings and rob your nation of its children," 14 therefore you will devour people no more or rob your nation[c] of its children, declares the Lord Yahweh. 15 I will no longer let you hear the nations' taunts; you will bear the peoples' scorn no more, and you will no longer make your nation stumble,[d] declares the Lord Yahweh.'"

16 Yahweh's word came to me: 17 "Son of man, when Israel's house lived on their own soil, they defiled it by their conduct and their deeds. In my sight their conduct was like the impurity of a woman in her monthly period. 18 So I emptied out my wrath upon them, because of the blood spilled on the land and the idols that had polluted it. 19 I scattered them among the nations, and they were dispersed through the lands. By their conduct and their deeds I judged them. 20 But wherever they came among the nations, they profaned my holy name, for people said of them, 'These are Yahweh's people, yet they had to leave his land.' 21 I cared, though, for my holy name, which Israel's house profaned among the nations where they went.

22 "So say to Israel's house: 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Not for your sake am I about to act, house of Israel, but for my holy name, which you have profaned among the nations where you went. 23 I will demonstrate the holiness of my great name, which has been dishonored among the nations—the name you dishonored among them. Declares the Lord Yahweh: the nations will know that I am Yahweh when I show my holiness through you before their eyes.[e] 24 "'I will pick you up from among the nations, collect you out of every country, and bring you to your own land. 25 I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean from all your impurities; from all your idols I will cleanse you. 26 I will give you a new heart and place a new spirit

inside you. From your body I will remove the heart of stone, and I will
give you a heart of flesh. 27 I will put my Spirit[f] within you and cause
you to walk in my statutes, and you will keep my rulings and carry
them out. 28 In the land I granted to your fathers you will dwell; you
will be a people to me, and I will be God to you. 29 I will save you from
all your impurities. I will call to the grain and make it abound, and I
will lay no famine on you. 30 I will multiply the fruit of the tree and the
produce of the field, so that among the nations you will never again
bear the shame of hunger. 31 Then you will remember your evil ways
and your deeds that were not good, and you will loathe yourselves
for your iniquities and your abominations. 32 Not for your sake am I
doing this, declares the Lord Yahweh—be sure of that. Be ashamed
and humiliated for your ways, house of Israel.
33 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: On the day I cleanse you from all your
iniquities, I will resettle the towns, and the ruins will be rebuilt. 34 The
desolate land will be worked, where once it lay a waste before the
eyes of every passerby. 35 They will say, "This land that was desolate
has become like the garden of Eden, and the towns that were ruined,
desolate, and torn down are now fortified and inhabited." 36 Then
the nations left around you will know that I, Yahweh, have rebuilt
what was torn down and replanted what was desolate. I, Yahweh,
have spoken, and I will do it. 37 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: Once
more I will let Israel's house seek this from me, and I will do it for
them: I will make their people as many as a flock. 38 Like the flock
for sacrifices, like Jerusalem's flock at her appointed feasts, so will
the ruined towns be filled with flocks of people. Then they will know
that I am Yahweh.'"

Notes

- a (36:2) Or "the everlasting high places."
- b (36:5) The Hebrew of the last clause is difficult.
- c (36:14) So the Hebrew margin and the Greek; the Hebrew text has "make your nation stumble."
- d (36:15) The Greek lacks this clause.
- e (36:23) Papyrus 967, one of the earliest known Greek manuscripts of Ezekiel (about AD 200), is reported to lack the passage from here ("And the nations will know…") through 36:38, and to place chapter 37 after chapters 38–39. Some scholars

see this as evidence of an earlier edition of the book; others think the passage was lost by accident. These details are given as reported in scholarly literature.

- f (36:27) Or “my spirit”; Hebrew ruach, also “wind” or “breath” (see 37:1–14).

Chapter 37

1 Yahweh’s hand came on me, and he carried me out by Yahweh’s Spirit[a] and set me down in the middle of the valley,[b] and it was full of bones. 2 He led me all around among them, and I saw a great many of them lying on the valley floor, and they were bone-dry. 3 He asked me, “Son of man, can these bones live again?” I replied, “Lord Yahweh, you alone know.” 4 Then he said to me, “Prophesy over these bones and tell them: Dry bones, hear Yahweh’s word! 5 The Lord Yahweh says this to these bones: I am going to bring breath[c] into you, and you will live. 6 I will attach tendons to you, bring flesh up over you, cover you with skin, and place breath inside you, and you will live. And you will know that I am Yahweh.”

7 So I prophesied as I had been commanded. While I prophesied a sound broke out, a clattering, and the bones drew together, bone joining bone. 8 As I watched, sinews were on them, flesh had grown, and skin covered them over, but there was no breath in them. 9 Then he said to me, “Prophesy to the breath; prophesy, son of man, and say to the breath: ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: From the four winds come, breath, and blow into these slain, so that they may live.’” 10 So I prophesied as he commanded me, and the breath entered them; they came to life and rose to their feet, an exceedingly vast army.

11 Then he said to me, “Son of man, these bones are the whole house of Israel. They keep saying, ‘Our bones are dried up, our hope has perished; we are cut off, every one of us.’ 12 So prophesy and say to them: ‘The Lord Yahweh says this: My people, I am going to open your graves and raise you up out of them, and I will bring you to Israel’s soil. 13 You will know that I am Yahweh, my people, when I open your graves and raise you up out of them. 14 I will place my Spirit inside you so that you live, and I will put you in your own land. Then you will know that I, Yahweh, have spoken and have acted, declares Yahweh.’”

15 Yahweh's word came to me: 16 "You, son of man, take a stick[d] and
write on it, 'For Judah and for the Israelites joined with him.' Then
take another stick and write on it, 'For Joseph, the stick of Ephraim,
and for all Israel's house joined with him.' 17 Bring them together into
one stick for yourself, so that they become one in your hand. 18 When
your people's children ask you, 'Will you not explain to us what you
mean by these?' 19 tell them, 'The Lord Yahweh says this: Look, I am
taking the stick of Joseph, which is in the hand of Ephraim, along with
the tribes of Israel that are his companions, and I will add Judah's
stick to it and make them into one stick, and in my hand they will
be one.'[e] 20 Hold the sticks you wrote on in your hand where they can
see them. 21 Then tell them: 'The Lord Yahweh says this: I am going to
take the Israelites from among the nations where they have gone. I
will gather them from every side and bring them to their own soil. 22 I
will make them one nation in the land, on Israel's mountains, and one
king will be king over all of them. They will no longer be two nations,
never again divided into two kingdoms. 23 They will never again make
themselves unclean with their idols, their vile images or any of their
crimes. I will rescue them from all the unfaithful acts by which they
sinned[f] and will cleanse them. In this way they will be my people,
and I will be their God. 24 "'My servant David will be king over them,
and there will be one shepherd for them all. They will walk in my
rulings and keep my statutes and do them. 25 They will live in the land
I gave my servant Jacob, where your fathers lived. There they will
dwell forever, they and their sons and their sons' sons, with David my
servant as their prince for all time. 26 I will make a covenant of peace
with them; an everlasting covenant it will be. I will establish them
and multiply them,[g] and I will set my sanctuary among them forever.
27 My dwelling place will be with them; I will be their God, and they
will be my people. 28 Then the nations will know that I, Yahweh, make
Israel holy, when my sanctuary is among them forever.'"

Notes

- a (37:1) Or "by the spirit of Yahweh"; Hebrew ruach, which can mean "spirit," "breath," or "wind." The word plays through vv. 1–14.
- b (37:1) Or "plain"; the same word as in 3:22–23.

- c (37:5) Hebrew ruach, also in vv. 6, 8–10; in v. 9 it is also "the four winds."
- d (37:16) Or "a piece of wood," perhaps a wooden writing tablet; also in vv. 16–20.
- e (37:19) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "one stick in the hand of Judah."
- f (37:23) Probable reading, following the Greek; the Hebrew has "from all their dwelling places in which they sinned."
- g (37:26) The Greek lacks "I will establish them and multiply them."

Chapter 38

1 Yahweh's word came to me: 2 "Son of man, turn your face toward Gog,[a] of the land of Magog,[b] the chief prince[c] of Meshech and Tubal, and prophesy against him. 3 Say: 'The Lord Yahweh says this: I am coming against you, Gog, chief prince of Meshech and Tubal. 4 I will turn you around, put hooks in your jaws, and lead you out with your whole army, horses and horsemen, all of them splendidly equipped, a vast company with large and small shields, every one of them wielding swords. 5 Persia, Cush, and Put[d] are with them, all with shield and helmet, 6 Gomer with all its battalions, Beth-togarmah[e] from the remotest north with all its battalions—a host of peoples go with you. 7 "'Be ready; make yourself ready, you and all the companies mustered around you, and be their guard.[f] 8 After many days you will be summoned.[g] In the latter years you will come against a land restored from the sword, whose people were gathered from many peoples onto Israel's mountains, which had long lain in ruins. Its people were brought out from the peoples, and now all of them live securely. 9 You will go up, advancing like a storm; like a cloud covering the land you will be, you and all your troops and many peoples with you.

10 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: On that day thoughts will rise in your mind, and you will devise an evil scheme. 11 You will say, "I will go up against a land of unwalled villages; I will fall on a quiet people who live in safety, all of them dwelling without walls, with neither bars nor gates," 12 to seize spoil and carry off plunder, to turn your hand against ruins now resettled and against a people gathered from the nations, who are acquiring livestock and goods and live at the center[h] of the earth. 13 Sheba and Dedan and the merchants of Tarshish[i] with all its young lions[j] will ask you, "Have you come to seize spoil? Have

you assembled your company to carry off plunder, to take away silver and gold, to seize livestock and goods, to take great spoil?"'
14 "So prophesy, son of man, and say to Gog: 'The Lord Yahweh says this: On that day, when my people Israel are living securely, will you not take notice?[k] 15 You will come from your home in the remotest part of the north, you and a great many nations with you, all of them on horseback, an enormous crowd and a powerful army. 16 You will march against my people Israel like a cloud covering the earth. In the last days it will come about that I will lead you against my land, so that the nations will know me when I show my holiness through you, Gog, in front of them.
17 "'The Lord Yahweh says this: Are you the one I was talking about long ago, through my servants the prophets of Israel? For years in those days they prophesied that I would lead you against them. 18 On that day, the day Gog comes against Israel's land, declares the Lord Yahweh, my fury will flare up in my nostrils. 19 In my jealousy and in the fire of my wrath I declare: On that day there will surely be a great earthquake in Israel's land. 20 Fish in the ocean, birds in the sky, wild animals, all the crawling creatures of the ground, and every person on earth will shake because of me. Mountains will be toppled, the cliffs[l] will collapse, and every wall will crash to the ground. 21 I will call for a sword against Gog on all my mountains,[m] declares the Lord Yahweh; each man's sword will be turned against his brother. 22 With plague and bloodshed I will enter into judgment with him. I will rain down on him and on his troops and on the many peoples with him a torrential downpour, hailstones, fire, and sulfur. 23 Thus I will display my greatness and my holiness and reveal myself before the eyes of many nations. Then they will know that I am Yahweh.'

Notes

- a (38:2) Gog is otherwise unknown. Some link the name to Gyges (Gugu), a seventh-century BC king of Lydia in western Asia Minor; in Ezekiel he is a ruler of the far north who leads the nations against Israel in the last days (compare Rev 20:8).
- b (38:2) Magog appears among the sons of Japheth in Gen 10:2. Here it seems to mean "the land of Gog."

- c (38:2) Or “the prince of Rosh”; Hebrew nesi rosh. The Greek takes Rosh as a name (“Rhos”). Also in v. 3 and 39:1. On Meshech and Tubal, peoples of central Asia Minor, see the note at 27:13.
- d (38:5) Cush is the Upper Nile region, south of Egypt; Put is probably Libya.
- e (38:6) Gomer is usually identified with the Cimmerians, and Beth-togarmah with a region in eastern Asia Minor (compare 27:14).
- f (38:7) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “you will be a guard for me.”
- g (38:8) Or “mustered”; or “punished.”
- h (38:12) Hebrew “the navel”; compare 5:5.
- i (38:13) The Greek has “Carthaginian merchants.” On Tarshish see the note at 27:12.
- j (38:13) Or “its young warriors”; the Greek has “all their villages.”
- k (38:14) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “will you not rise up?”
- l (38:20) Or “the terraces”; the Hebrew word is rare.
- m (38:21) Hebrew uncertain; the Greek has “I will summon every terror against him.”

Chapter 39

1 “And you, son of man, prophesy against Gog and say: ‘The Lord
Yahweh says this: I am coming against you, Gog, chief prince of
Meshech and Tubal. 2 I will turn you around and drive you on,[a] bring
you up from the far reaches of the north, and lead you against Israel’s
mountains. 3 Then out of your left hand I will knock your bow, and
out of your right I will dash your arrows. 4 On Israel’s mountains you
will fall, you and all your troops and the peoples with you. I will hand
you over as food to every winged scavenger and to the beasts of the
field. 5 In the open field you will fall, for I have spoken, declares the
Lord Yahweh. 6 Fire I will send on Magog[b] and on those who dwell
at ease in the coastlands, and they will know that I am Yahweh. 7 “‘I
will make my holy name known among my people Israel, and never
again will I allow my holy name to be dishonored. Then the nations
will know that I am Yahweh, the Holy One in Israel. 8 It is coming! It
will surely happen, declares the Lord Yahweh. This is the day I have
spoken of.
9 “‘Then those who live in Israel’s towns will go out and make fires
of the weapons and burn them—small and large shields, bows and
arrows, war clubs and spears. For seven years they will make fires of
them. 10 They will not have to collect firewood from the countryside or

cut it in the forests, because they will burn the weapons for fuel. They will rob those who robbed them and plunder those who plundered them, declares the Lord Yahweh.
11 "'On that day I will give Gog a grave site there in Israel, the Valley of the Travelers,[c] on the east side of the Sea.[d] It will bar the travelers' way, for there Gog and all his horde will be buried, and it will be called the Valley of Hamon-gog.[e] 12 For seven months Israel's house will be burying them, to cleanse the land. 13 All the land's people will take part in the burying, and the day I display my glory will win them a name, declares the Lord Yahweh. 14 They will set apart men to pass continually through the land, burying those[f] left lying on the ground, so as to cleanse it. At the end of seven months they will begin their search. 15 As they travel through the land, if any of them sees a human bone, he will put up a sign next to it, and it will stay until the gravediggers have buried it in the Valley of Hamon-gog. 16 A city too will be named Hamonah.[g] So they will cleanse the land.'
17 "As for you, son of man, the Lord Yahweh says this: Tell every kind of bird and every wild animal: 'Gather together and come! Assemble from every side for the sacrificial feast I am slaughtering for you, a huge feast on the mountains of Israel, where you will eat meat and drink blood. 18 You will eat the flesh of warriors and drink the blood of the rulers of the earth—rams, lambs, goats and bulls, every one of them well-fed animals from Bashan.[h] 19 At the feast I am slaughtering for you, you will eat fat until you are stuffed and drink blood until you are intoxicated. 20 At my table you will be filled with horses and riders,[i] with warriors and soldiers of every kind, declares the Lord Yahweh.'
21 "I will set my glory among the nations, and all the nations will see the judgment I carry out and the hand I lay on them. 22 From that day on, Israel's house will know that I am Yahweh their God. 23 And the nations will know that Israel's house went into exile for their iniquity, because they were unfaithful to me. So I hid my face from them and gave them into the hand of their foes, and all of them fell by the sword. 24 As their impurity and their rebellions deserved, I dealt with them and hid my face from them.

25 “So the Lord Yahweh says this: Now I will turn back the captivity[j]
of Jacob and show mercy to all of Israel’s house, and I will be
zealous for my holy name. 26 They will forget[k] their disgrace and all
the unfaithfulness they showed me, when they live securely on their
own soil with no one to frighten them. 27 When I bring them back
from the peoples and gather them from their enemies’ lands, I will
show myself holy through them in the sight of many nations. 28 Then
they will know that I am Yahweh their God, who sent them into exile
among the nations and then gathered them to their own soil, leaving
none of them behind there any longer.[l] 29 Never again will I hide my
face from them, for I will have poured out my Spirit on Israel’s house,
declares the Lord Yahweh.”

Notes

- a (39:2) The Hebrew verb is found only here; the Greek has “guide you.”
- b (39:6) The Greek has “on Gog.”
- c (39:11) Hebrew Oberim; or, with a slight change, “the Valley of Abarim,” the mountain range east of the Dead Sea.
- d (39:11) That is, the Dead Sea.
- e (39:11) Meaning “Gog’s horde.”
- f (39:14) Meaning “horde.” The Hebrew of this clause is difficult; the Greek has “the name of the city will be Burial-place.”
- g (39:16) Hebrew “the passers-by, those left”; the Greek lacks “the passers-by.”
- h (39:18) Bashan, east of the Sea of Galilee, was famed for its cattle (compare Amos 4:1).
- i (39:20) Or “chariots.”
- j (39:25) Or “restore the fortunes.”
- k (39:26) So many interpreters, with a slight change of vowels; the Hebrew has “They will bear.”
- l (39:28) The Greek lacks the last part of this verse, from “and then gathered them.”

Chapter 40

1 In the twenty-fifth year of our exile, at the beginning of the year,
on the tenth day of the month,[a] in the fourteenth year after the city
was struck down, on that very day Yahweh’s hand came on me, and
he brought me there. 2 In visions of God he brought me to Israel’s
land and set me down on a very high mountain, on which there was
something like the structure of a city, to the south.[b] 3 When he had
brought me there, I saw a man whose appearance shone like bronze,

holding a linen cord and a measuring reed, standing in the gateway.
4 The man said to me, “Son of man, look with your eyes and listen
with your ears, and give your attention to everything I am going to
show you, for you were brought here so that I could show it to you.
Tell Israel’s house everything you see.”
5 There was a wall surrounding the temple area[c] on all sides. In the
man’s hand was a measuring reed 10.5 feet long, measured in long
cubits, each a cubit and a handbreadth.[d] He measured the wall: it was
10.5 feet thick and 10.5 feet high.[e] 6 Then he came to the gate that
faced east. He climbed its steps and measured the threshold[f] of the
gate: 10.5 feet deep.[g] 7 Each guardroom[h] was 10.5 feet long and 10.5
feet wide, and between the guardrooms the space was 8.75 feet. The
threshold of the gate beside the vestibule of the gate, on the inner
side, was 10.5 feet.[i] 8 Then he measured the vestibule of the gate on the
inner side: 10.5 feet.[jk] 9 He measured the vestibule of the gate: 14 feet;
and its jambs:[l] 3.5 feet.[m] The vestibule of the gate was on the inner
side. 10 The guardrooms of the east gate were three on each side, all
three with the same measurement, and the jambs on each side had the
same measurement. 11 He measured the width of the gate’s entrance,
17.5 feet, and the length[n] of the gateway, about 23 feet.[o] 12 In front of
the guardrooms was a barrier 21 inches wide on each side, and the
guardrooms were 10.5 feet square on each side.[p] 13 He measured the
gate from the back[q] of one guardroom to the back of the other: the
width was about 44 feet,[r] from one doorway to the opposite doorway.
14 He also measured[s] the jambs: 105 feet;[t] the court reached up to the
jamb all around the gateway. 15 The distance from the face of the outer
gateway to the face of the gate’s inner vestibule was 87.5 feet.[u] 16 The
guardrooms and their jambs had narrow[v] windows all around on the
inside of the gateway, and the vestibules likewise had windows all
around on the inside. On each jamb were palm-tree carvings.
17 Then he brought me into the outer court, and there were rooms
and a pavement laid all around the court; thirty rooms faced the
pavement. 18 The pavement ran alongside the gates, matching the
length of the gates; this was the lower pavement. 19 He measured the

distance from the front of the lower gate to the front of the inner court on the outside: 175 feet,[w] on the east and on the north.[x]
20 Next, the gate of the outer courtyard that faced north: he measured both its length and its width. 21 Its guardrooms, three on each side, its jambs, and its vestibule had the same measurements as the first gate: 87.5 feet long and about 44 feet wide.[y] 22 Its windows, its vestibule, and its palm carvings were measured like the east-facing gate. People climbed up to it by seven steps, with its vestibule in front of them. 23 Across from the north gate, just as on the east side, there was a gate leading to the inner courtyard. He measured the distance from one gate to the other: 175 feet.[z]
24 Then he brought me around to the southern side, where there was a gate facing south. He measured its doorposts and its porch, and they matched the dimensions of the others. 25 It and its vestibule had windows all around, like the other windows. It was 87.5 feet long and about 44 feet wide.[aa] 26 Seven steps went up to it, with its vestibule in front of them, and it had palm carvings on its jambs, one on each side. 27 The inner court too had a gate facing south, and he measured from gate to gate toward the south: 175 feet.[ab]
28 Next he took me by the south gate into the inner court and measured that gate; its dimensions were like these. 29 Its guardrooms, jambs, and vestibule had the same measurements as the others, and it and its vestibule had windows all around. It was 87.5 feet long and about 44 feet wide.[ac] 30 There were vestibules all around, about 44 feet long and 8.75 feet[ad] wide.[ae] 31 Its vestibule faced the outer court; its jambs bore palm carvings, and eight steps formed its ascent.
32 Then he brought me into the inner court on the east side, and measured the gate there; its dimensions were like these. 33 Its guardrooms, jambs, and vestibule had the same measurements as the others, and it and its vestibule had windows all around. It was 87.5 feet long and about 44 feet wide.[af] 34 Its vestibule faced the outer court; palm carvings were on its jambs on each side, and its stairway had eight steps.
35 He took me to the north gate and measured it by the same dimensions, 36 as did its guardrooms, jambs, and vestibule. It had windows

all around. It was 87.5 feet long and about 44 feet wide.[ag] 37 Its jambs[ah]
faced the outer court; palm carvings were on its jambs on each side,
and its stairway had eight steps.
38 There was a room with its doorway by the jambs of the gates;[ai]
there they would wash the burnt offering. 39 In the porch of the gate,
on each side, stood two tables, to be used for slaughtering the burnt
offering, the sin offering and the guilt offering. 40 On the outer side, as
one goes up to the entrance of the north gate, were two tables, and
on the other side of the gate's vestibule were two tables. 41 So there
were four tables on one side and four on the other, beside the gate:
eight tables on which they slaughtered. 42 There were also four tables
of dressed stone for the burnt offering, 31.5 inches long, 31.5 inches
wide, and 21 inches high.[aj] On them they would lay the implements
used for slaughtering the burnt offering and the sacrifices. 43 Ledges[ak]
3 inches wide were fastened all around inside,[al] and on the tables was
the flesh of the offerings.
44 Outside the inner gate, in the inner court, there were rooms for the
singers.[am] One was beside the north gate and faced south; the other
was beside the south[an] gate and faced north. 45 He said to me, "This
room facing south is for the priests who keep charge of the temple, 46
and the room facing north is for the priests who keep charge of the
altar. These are the sons of Zadok,[ao] who alone among Levi's descen-
dants may come near to Yahweh to minister to him." 47 He measured
the court: 175 feet long and 175 feet wide,[ap] a square. The altar stood
in front of the temple.
48 Then he brought me to the temple's vestibule and measured the
jambs of the vestibule, 8.75 feet on each side. The width of the
gateway was 24.5 feet, and its side walls were 5.25 feet[aq] on each side.[ar]
49 The vestibule was 35 feet wide[as] and 21 feet[at] deep.[au] It was reached
by steps,[av] and there were pillars beside the jambs, one on each side.

Notes

- a (40:1) The Hebrew has rosh hashanah, "the beginning (head) of the year," without naming the month; the Greek has "in the first month." If the first month (Nisan) is meant, the date falls in March–April (April 573 BC); some interpreters

think of the autumn new year (Tishri, September–October). The vision comes twenty-five years after King Jehoiachin's exile in 597 BC.

- b (40:2) The Greek has "opposite me."
- c (40:5) Hebrew "the house," Ezekiel's usual word for the temple.
- d (40:5) The "long cubit" used in Ezekiel's temple vision is a standard cubit (about 18 inches) plus a handbreadth (about 3 inches), so about 21 inches (53 cm). The reed of six long cubits is about 10.5 feet (3.2 m). All figures in chapters 40–48 are converted on this basis; they are approximate.
- e (40:5) Hebrew: 6 cubits (about 3.2 m); 1 reed (about 3.2 m); 1 reed (about 3.2 m).
- f (40:6) The Hebrew adds "and one threshold, one reed deep," probably an accidental repetition; the Greek lacks it.
- g (40:6) Hebrew: 1 reed (about 3.2 m).
- h (40:7) Or "alcove"; the small rooms lining the gate passage, three on each side (v. 10).
- i (40:7) Hebrew: 1 reed (about 3.2 m); 1 reed (about 3.2 m); 5 cubits (about 2.6 m); 1 reed (about 3.2 m).
- j (40:8) Hebrew: 1 reed (about 3.2 m).
- k (40:8) The Hebrew of vv. 7b–8 seems to repeat itself; the Greek has a different text here.
- l (40:9) Or "pilasters"; the Hebrew word may refer to projecting door-posts.
- m (40:9) Hebrew: 8 cubits (about 4.2 m); 2 cubits (about 1.1 m).
- n (40:11) Or "depth"; possibly the length of the passage.
- o (40:11) Hebrew: 10 cubits (about 5.3 m); 13 cubits (about 6.8 m).
- p (40:12) Hebrew: 1 cubit (about 53 cm); 6 cubits (about 3.2 m).
- q (40:13) Hebrew "roof," probably the outer wall of each room.
- r (40:13) Hebrew: 25 cubits (about 13 m).
- s (40:14) Hebrew "he made"; the verse is difficult. The Greek has "the open space of the porch of the gate outside was twenty cubits."
- t (40:14) Hebrew: 60 cubits (about 32 m).
- u (40:15) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m).
- v (40:16) Or "latticed"; the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- w (40:19) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- x (40:19) The last phrase in the Hebrew is difficult; the Greek joins "and he brought me to the north" to v. 20.
- y (40:21) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 25 cubits (about 13 m).
- z (40:23) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- aa (40:25) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 25 cubits (about 13 m).
- ab (40:27) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- ac (40:29) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 25 cubits (about 13 m).
- ad (40:30) Hebrew: 25 cubits (about 13 m); 5 cubits (about 2.6 m).
- ae (40:30) The Greek lacks this verse.
- af (40:33) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 25 cubits (about 13 m).

- ag (40:36) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 25 cubits (about 13 m).
- ah (40:37) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “Its vestibule.”
- ai (40:38) The Hebrew of this verse is uncertain; the Greek is quite different.
- aj (40:42) Hebrew: 1 and a half cubits (about 79 cm); 1 and a half cubits (about 79 cm); 1 cubit (about 53 cm).
- ak (40:43) Or “Rims”; the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- al (40:43) Hebrew: 1 handbreadth (about 8 cm).
- am (40:44) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “two rooms.”
- an (40:44) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “east.”
- ao (40:46) Zadok means “righteous.” He served as priest under David and Solomon (2 Samuel 8:17; 1 Kings 1–2).
- ap (40:47) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m); 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- aq (40:48) Hebrew: 5 cubits (about 2.6 m); 3 cubits (about 1.6 m).
- ar (40:48) The Greek adds “and the width of the door was fourteen cubits” (long cubits; about 24.5 feet; 7.4 m), which is supplied here; the Hebrew lacks the width of the gateway.
- as (40:49) Hebrew “long.”
- at (40:49) Hebrew: 20 cubits (about 11 m); 12 cubits (about 6.3 m).
- au (40:49) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “eleven cubits.”
- av (40:49) The Greek has “ten steps.”

Chapter 41

1 Then he brought me into the nave[a] and measured the jambs: 10.5 feet[b] wide on each side was the width of the jambs.[c] 2 The entrance was 17.5 feet wide, and the side walls of the entrance were 8.75 feet on each side. He measured the nave: 70 feet long and 35 feet wide.[d] 3 Then he went on inside and measured the jambs of the entrance, 3.5 feet; the entrance itself, 10.5 feet; and the width[e] of the entrance, about 12 feet.[f] 4 He measured its length, 35 feet, and its width, 35 feet,[g] facing the nave. And he said to me, “This is the most holy place.”

5 Then he measured the temple’s wall: 10.5 feet thick. The side rooms all around the temple were each 7 feet wide.[h] 6 The side rooms were in three stories, one above another, thirty in each story.[i] Offsets ran around the house’s wall, entering it to hold the rooms up, yet without the rooms being fastened into the house’s wall. 7 The side rooms grew wider as they rose, story by story, for the structure surrounding the temple went up by stages all around it. So the temple was broader toward the top, and one went up from the lowest story through the

middle story to the highest.[j] 8 Looking, I saw a raised base encircling
the house; the footings of the side rooms measured a full reed, 10.5
feet[k] to the joint.[l] 9 The outer wall of the side rooms was 8.75 feet
thick.[m] The open area between the temple's side rooms 10 and the
priests' rooms[n] was 35 feet wide all around the temple.[o] 11 The doors
of the side rooms opened onto the free space, one door on the north
and one on the south; and the free space was 8.75 feet wide all the
way around.[p]
12 The building facing the temple yard[q] on the west side was about 123
feet wide, its wall was 8.75 feet thick all around, and it was about 158
feet long.[r]
13 Then he measured the temple: 175 feet long; and the yard and the
building with its walls: 175 feet long.[s]
14 The width of the temple's front, together with the yard on the east,
was 175 feet.[t]
15 He measured the length of the building facing the yard at the rear,
with its galleries[u] on either side: 175 feet.

¶The nave, the inner room,[v] and the vestibules of the court,
16 the thresholds, the narrow windows, and the galleries round the
three of them opposite the threshold, had wood overlaying them on
every side, from ground level as far as the windows (the windows
were covered),[w]
17 to the space above the entrance, and on into the inner room and on
the outside. On every wall all around, inside and out, were carvings
in measured panels:[x]
18 cherubim alternating with palm trees, a palm standing between
cherub and cherub. Every cherub had two faces:
19 a human face turned toward the palm tree on one side, and a young
lion's face turned to the palm on the far side. So it was carved over
the entire house, round and round.
20 From ground level up over the entrance the cherubim and palms
were carved, and on the nave's wall.[y]
21 The nave had squared doorposts. Before the holy place stood what
appeared to be 22 an altar of wood, 5.25 feet high and 3.5 feet[z] long.[aa]
Its corners, its base,[ab] and its sides were of wood. He told me, "This is

the table that stands before Yahweh." 23 The nave and the holy place each had a double door. 24 Each door had two leaves, two swinging leaves, two for one door and two for the other. 25 Cherubim and palm trees were carved on the doors of the main hall, just as they were on the walls, and a wooden canopy[ac] stood over the front of the porch outside. 26 There were narrow windows and palm trees on both sides of the vestibule, on its side walls, and on the temple's side rooms and canopies.

Notes

- a (41:1) Hebrew hekal, the main hall of the temple, also called "the holy place."
- b (41:1) Hebrew: 6 cubits (about 3.2 m).
- c (41:1) The Hebrew adds "the width of the tent"; the Greek differs here.
- d (41:2) Hebrew: 10 cubits (about 5.3 m); 5 cubits (about 2.6 m); 40 cubits (about 21 m); 20 cubits (about 11 m).
- e (41:3) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "and the side walls of the entrance were seven cubits on each side."
- f (41:3) Hebrew: 2 cubits (about 1.1 m); 6 cubits (about 3.2 m); 7 cubits (about 3.7 m).
- g (41:4) Hebrew: 20 cubits (about 11 m); 20 cubits (about 11 m).
- h (41:5) Hebrew: 6 cubits (about 3.2 m); 4 cubits (about 2.1 m).
- i (41:6) Hebrew "side room upon side room, three and thirty times," usually understood as three stories of thirty rooms; the Greek has "twice ninety."
- j (41:7) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult.
- k (41:8) Hebrew: 6 cubits (about 3.2 m).
- l (41:8) Or "a full reed of six great cubits." The Hebrew word atsilah is uncertain.
- m (41:9) Hebrew: 5 cubits (about 2.6 m).
- n (41:10) Probably the rooms described in 42:1–14.
- o (41:10) Hebrew: 20 cubits (about 11 m).
- p (41:11) Hebrew: 5 cubits (about 2.6 m).
- q (41:12) Hebrew gizrah, "the separate place," a restricted open area behind the temple; also in vv. 13–15.
- r (41:12) Hebrew: 70 cubits (about 37 m); 5 cubits (about 2.6 m); 90 cubits (about 47 m).
- s (41:13) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m); 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- t (41:14) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- u (41:15) The Hebrew word, also in v. 16 and 42:3, 5, is of uncertain meaning; it may mean "terraces" or "passages."
- v (41:15) Hebrew "the inner nave," the most holy place.
- w (41:16) The Hebrew of vv. 15b–17 is difficult.

- x (41:17) Hebrew “measures,” perhaps meaning “panels” or “(were) measured”; the sense is uncertain.
- y (41:20) The Hebrew of the last words is uncertain.
- z (41:22) Hebrew: 3 cubits (about 1.6 m); 2 cubits (about 1.1 m).
- aa (41:22) The Greek adds “and two cubits wide” (about 1.1 m).
- ab (41:22) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “its length.”
- ac (41:25) Or “threshold”; the Hebrew word is uncertain.

Chapter 42

1 Then he led me out into the outer court by the road going north
and brought me to the rooms that lay opposite the restricted yard
and opposite the building on the north. 2 Along its length of 175 feet
was the north door,[a] and the width was 87.5 feet.[b] 3 Across from the
35-foot area[c] that belonged to the inner courtyard, and across from
the paving that belonged to the outer courtyard, the galleries faced
each other on three levels. 4 Before the rooms was a passage 17.5 feet
wide on the inner side, a way of 21 inches;[de] their doors faced north.
5 The uppermost rooms were cut short, since the galleries ate into
them more than into the building’s lowest and middle rooms. 6 For
they were in three stories and had no pillars like the courts’ pillars; so
the upper rooms were set back from the ground more than the lower
and the middle ones. 7 There was a wall outside, parallel to the rooms,
toward the outer court, in front of the rooms; its length was 87.5 feet.[f]
8 For the rooms on the outer court’s side were 87.5 feet long, while
those facing the nave were 175 feet.[g] 9 Below these rooms was the
entrance[h] from the east, as one comes into them from the outer court.
10 In the thickness of the court’s wall on the east side,[i] facing the
restricted yard and facing the building, there were rooms too, 11 with
a passage before them. They looked like the rooms on the north, with
the same length and width, and with all the same exits, arrangements,
and doors. 12 Matching the doors of the rooms on the south side there
was a door at the head of the passage, the way in front of the matching
wall eastward, where one enters them.[j]
13 Then he told me, “The north rooms and the south rooms that face
the restricted yard are the holy rooms, where the priests who draw
near to Yahweh will eat the most holy offerings. There they will lay

down the most holy offerings: the grain offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering, for the place is holy. 14 Once the priests have gone in, they must not go out from the holy place into the outer court until they lay aside there the garments in which they minister, for these are holy. They must put on other clothes before they approach the area belonging to the people."

15 When he had finished measuring the inner temple, he led me out by the gate facing east and measured the whole area round about. 16 With the measuring reed he measured the east side:[k] 5,250 feet by the measuring reed,[l] all around. 17 He measured the north side: 5,250 feet by the reed,[m] all around. 18 The south side he measured: 5,250 feet by the measuring reed.[n] 19 He turned to the west side and measured 5,250 feet by the measuring reed.[o] 20 On all four sides he measured it. It had a wall around it, 5,250 feet long and 5,250 feet wide,[p] to separate what is holy from what is common.

Notes

- a (42:2) The Hebrew is difficult; it may mean "the rooms whose door faced north were 175 feet long." The Greek has "a hundred cubits in length toward the north."
- b (42:2) Hebrew: 100 cubits (about 53 m); 50 cubits (about 26 m).
- c (42:3) Hebrew "the twenty," that is, 20 cubits (about 10.5 m), the open area described in 41:10.
- d (42:4) Hebrew: 10 cubits (about 5.3 m); 1 cubit (about 53 cm).
- e (42:4) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "the length reaching to a hundred cubits."
- f (42:7) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m).
- g (42:8) Hebrew: 50 cubits (about 26 m); 100 cubits (about 53 m).
- h (42:9) So the written Hebrew text; the Hebrew margin has "the one who brings in."
- i (42:10) So the Greek; the Hebrew has "east."
- j (42:12) The Hebrew of v. 12 is difficult.
- k (42:16) So the Hebrew margin; the written Hebrew text has "five cubits, reeds." The Greek has "five hundred cubits" here and in vv. 17–20, which would make the area about 875 feet (263 m) on each side.
- l (42:16) Hebrew: 500 reeds (about 1.6 km).
- m (42:17) Hebrew: 500 reeds (about 1.6 km).
- n (42:18) Hebrew: 500 reeds (about 1.6 km).
- o (42:19) Hebrew: 500 reeds (about 1.6 km).
- p (42:20) Hebrew "five hundred long and five hundred wide," without a unit; reeds are presumed from vv. 16–19. Five hundred reeds is about 5,250 feet (about 1.6 km).

Chapter 43

1 Then he led me to the gate, the gate facing east. 2 And there was
the glory of Israel's God, coming from the east! Its sound was like
the roar of many waters,[a] and the earth was lit up by his glory. 3 The
vision was like the one I saw when I[b] came to destroy the city, and
like the visions I saw beside the Kebar River; and I fell facedown. 4
Yahweh's glory entered the temple by way of the gate that faced east.
5 Then the Spirit lifted me and brought me into the inner court, and
there the glory of Yahweh had filled the temple!
6 I heard one addressing me out of the house, while the man was
standing at my side. 7 He told me, "Son of man, here is my throne's
place, the spot where my feet rest, where I will make my home amid
Israel's people for all time. Never again will Israel's house defile
my holy name, neither they nor their kings, through their whoring
and through their kings' corpses[c] at their high places.[d] 8 They placed
their doorsill next to my doorsill and their doorpost right beside my
doorpost, with just a wall separating me from them. By the detestable
things they did they made my holy name unclean, so I destroyed them
in my anger. 9 Now let them put far from me their prostitution and
the corpses of their kings,[e] and I will dwell among them forever.
10 "As for you, son of man, describe the temple to Israel's house, so
that they may be ashamed of their iniquities, and let them measure
its plan. 11 If they are ashamed[f] of everything they have done, show
them the temple's plan and arrangement: its exits and entrances, all
its forms, all its regulations and all its instructions. Write this down
while they watch, so they can follow its complete plan and all its
regulations and carry them out. 12 This is the law of the temple: on the
mountaintop its whole territory all around will be most holy. Look,
this is the law of the temple.
13 "These are the measurements of the altar in cubits (the cubit here
is a cubit and a handbreadth[g]): its base[h] measures 21 inches in depth
and 21 inches across, and the lip at its edge, all around, is 10.5 inches.[i]
And this is the altar's height:[j] 14 from the base on the ground up to
the lower ledge, 3.5 feet, with a width of 21 inches; and from the
smaller ledge to the larger ledge, 7 feet, with a width of 21 inches.[k]

15 The altar hearth[l] is 7 feet high,[m] and from the hearth four horns
project upward.[n] 16 Four-square is the hearth: 21 feet in length, 21 feet
in width,[o] on all four sides. 17 The ledge is also square, 24.5 feet long
by 24.5 feet wide on its four sides, with a rim of 10.5 inches around it
and a base of 21 inches all around.[p] Its steps face east."
18 Then he said to me, "Son of man, this is what Lord Yahweh says:
Here are the altar's rules for the day it is made, for offering burnt
offerings on it and for splashing blood on it. 19 You are to give to the
Levitical priests of Zadok's line, who come near to me to minister to
me, declares Lord Yahweh, a young bull for a sin offering. 20 You will
take some of its blood and put it on the four horns of the altar, on
the four corners of the ledge, and on the rim all around; so you will
purify it and make atonement for it. 21 You are then to take the bull
for the sin offering and burn it at the designated place in the temple
area, outside the holy place. 22 On the second day you will offer a
male goat without defect[q] for a sin offering, and they will purify the
altar as they purified it with the bull. 23 Once you have completed the
cleansing, present an unblemished young bull and an unblemished
ram from the flock. 24 You will present them before Yahweh, and the
priests will throw salt on them and offer them as a burnt offering to
Yahweh. 25 For seven days you will provide a goat each day as a sin
offering; a young bull and a ram from the flock, both without defect,
are also to be provided. 26 For seven days they are to make atonement
for the altar and purify it; in this way they will dedicate it.[r] 27 When
these days are over, from the eighth day onward the priests will offer
your burnt offerings and your fellowship offerings on the altar, and I
will accept you, declares Lord Yahweh."

Notes

- a (43:2) The Greek has "a voice of an army, as the sound of many redoubling their shouts."
- b (43:3) So the Hebrew; some ancient witnesses have "he." The Greek has "when I went in to anoint the city."
- c (43:7) Or "memorial monuments"; the Hebrew word can mean both.
- d (43:7) So the Hebrew; some ancient witnesses read "at their death."
- e (43:9) The Greek has "the murders of their princes."
- f (43:11) The Greek has "and they will bear their punishment."

- g (43:13) See the note at 40:5. A handbreadth is about 3 inches (7.5 cm).
- h (43:13) Hebrew "bosom," the gutter or base around the altar's foot; also in vv. 14, 17.
- i (43:13) Hebrew: 1 cubit (about 53 cm); 1 cubit (about 53 cm); 1 span (about 26 cm).
- j (43:13) So the Greek; the Hebrew has "its back" or "its mound."
- k (43:14) Hebrew: 2 cubits (about 1.1 m); 1 cubit (about 53 cm); 4 cubits (about 2.1 m); 1 cubit (about 53 cm).
- l (43:15) Hebrew har'el, perhaps "mountain of God"; in v. 15b and v. 16 the written Hebrew text has ari'el, which may mean "hearth of God" (compare Isaiah 29:1).
- m (43:15) Hebrew: 4 cubits (about 2.1 m).
- n (43:15) The Greek has "and above the horns, a cubit."
- o (43:16) Hebrew: 12 cubits (about 6.3 m); 12 cubits (about 6.3 m).
- p (43:17) Hebrew: 14 cubits (about 7.4 m); 14 cubits (about 7.4 m); half a cubit (about 26 cm); 1 cubit (about 53 cm).
- q (43:22) The Greek has "two kids of the goats without defect."
- r (43:26) Hebrew "fill its hand," an idiom for consecration; the Greek has "and they will consecrate themselves."

Chapter 44

1 Then he brought me back toward the sanctuary's outer gate, the one
facing east, and it was shut. 2 Yahweh told me, "This gate is to stay
shut. It must not be opened, and no one may go in through it, because
Yahweh, Israel's God, has entered by it. So it must remain shut. 3 Only
the prince[a] may sit in it, as prince, to eat bread before Yahweh. By the
gate's vestibule he will come in, and by the same way he will go out."
4 Next he led me through the north gate to the house's front. As I
looked, there was Yahweh's glory filling Yahweh's house! I fell on my
face. 5 Yahweh said to me, "Son of man, set your mind on this; look
with your eyes and listen with your ears to all I am telling you about
every statute of Yahweh's house and all its laws. Take careful note
of who may enter the house and of all who must be kept out of the
sanctuary.[b] 6 Say to the rebellious ones,[c] to Israel's house, 'This is what
Lord Yahweh says: Enough of all your detestable practices, house of
Israel! 7 You brought in outsiders, people uncircumcised in heart and
in body, to occupy my sanctuary and make my house unclean, while
you presented my food—the fat and the blood. And they[d] violated
my covenant, in addition to all your detestable practices. 8 You did

not keep charge of my holy things yourselves, but you set them[e] as keepers of my charge in my sanctuary for yourselves. 9 This is what Lord Yahweh says: No foreigner uncircumcised in heart and flesh may enter my sanctuary, not one of the foreigners living among the Israelites.
10 "'As for the Levites who went far from me when Israel strayed, who wandered from me after their idols,[f] they will bear their guilt. 11 They will be servants in my sanctuary, overseeing the gates of the house and serving the house. They will slaughter the burnt offering and the sacrifice for the people, and they will stand before the people to serve them. 12 Because they served them before their idols and became a stumbling block of guilt for Israel's house, I have raised my hand in an oath against them, declares Lord Yahweh, that they will bear their guilt. 13 They must not come near me to serve me as priests, nor approach anything of mine that is holy, nor the most holy things. Their shame they must carry, and the detestable acts they committed.[g] 14 I will make them caretakers of the house's duties, for all its work and all that is to be done in it.
15 "'But the Levitical priests, the sons of Zadok, who kept charge of my sanctuary when the Israelites strayed from me, will come near me to serve me. They will stand before me to offer me fat and blood, declares Lord Yahweh. 16 They will enter my sanctuary, and they will come near my table to serve me and keep my charge. 17 When they come through the gates of the inner courtyard, they are to put on linen clothing. They must wear nothing made of wool while they are on duty at those gates or inside the courtyard. 18 Linen turbans will be on their heads and linen undergarments on their waists. They must not bind on anything that causes sweat.[h] 19 When they go out into the outer courtyard where the people are,[i] they must take off the clothing they served in, store it in the sacred chambers, and put on different clothing, so that they will not transmit holiness to the people by their clothing. 20 They must not shave their heads or let their hair grow long; they must keep their hair trimmed. 21 Wine is not for any priest to drink on entering the inner court. 22 They must not marry a widow or a divorced woman, but only virgins from the descendants

of Israel's house, or a widow who is a priest's widow.[j] 23 They will
teach my people the difference between holy and common, and show
them how to tell unclean from clean. 24 In a dispute,[k] they will stand
to judge, and they will judge it by my judgments. They will keep my
laws and my statutes at all my appointed feasts, and they will keep
my Sabbaths holy. 25 A priest must not go near a dead person and
so become unclean. For a father or mother, son or daughter, brother
or unmarried sister, however, they may make themselves unclean.
26 After he is cleansed, seven days are to be counted for him.[l] 27 On
the day he enters the sanctuary, into the inner courtyard, to serve in
the holy place, he is to present his own sin offering, declares Lord
Yahweh.
28 "'This will be their inheritance:[m] I am their inheritance. Grant
them no holding in Israel; their holding is me. 29 They will eat the
grain offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering, and everything
devoted[n] in Israel will be theirs. 30 The priests will have the best of all
the firstfruits of everything, and of each gift you set apart, whatever it
is. The first of your dough[o] you are to hand to the priest, and blessing
will come to rest upon your household. 31 No carcass, nothing mauled,
whether bird or beast, may the priests eat.

Notes

- a (44:3) Hebrew nasi', a leader or chief; Ezekiel uses this title rather than "king" for Israel's ruler in chapters 40–48.
- b (44:5) The Hebrew is difficult; literally "to the entrance of the house with all the exits of the sanctuary."
- c (44:6) So the Hebrew; the Greek lacks "the rebellious ones" and has "the provoking house."
- d (44:7) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "you."
- e (44:8) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "you appointed others."
- f (44:10) Hebrew gillulim, a scornful word for idols, perhaps "dung pellets."
- g (44:13) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "for the error in which they erred."
- h (44:18) The Greek has "they must not tightly gird themselves."
- i (44:19) The Hebrew repeats "to the outer court"; the Greek has it once.
- j (44:22) Hebrew "a widow who is a widow from a priest."
- k (44:24) The Greek has "in a judgment of blood."
- l (44:26) The Hebrew has "for him"; the sense is that he waits seven more days after his cleansing.

- m (44:28) So the Hebrew; some ancient witnesses read “They will have no inheritance.”
- n (44:29) Hebrew cherem, anything set apart irrevocably for God.
- o (44:30) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; it may mean “coarse meal.”

Chapter 45

1 “When you allot the land as an inheritance, you are to set apart a
contribution for Yahweh, a holy portion of the land, about 8.3 miles
long and about 3.3 miles[a] wide.[b] It will be holy throughout its whole
area.[c] 2 Of this, a square plot 875 feet by 875 feet will belong to the
sanctuary, with 87.5 feet of open land around it.[d] 3 From this measured
area you are to measure off a strip about 8.3 miles long and about 3.3
miles wide;[e] in it will stand the sanctuary, the most holy place. 4 It is a
holy portion of the land, and it will belong to the priests who minister
in the sanctuary, who come near to serve Yahweh. It will be a place
for their houses and a holy place for the sanctuary. 5 A strip about 8.3
miles long and about 3.3 miles wide will belong to the Levites who
serve the house,[f] as their possession for towns to live in.[g]
6 “Alongside the holy contribution you are to assign as the city’s
property an area about 1.7 miles wide and about 8.3 miles long.[h] It
will belong to the whole house of Israel.
7 “The prince will have land on both sides of the holy contribution
and the city’s property, bordering the holy contribution and the city’s
property, on the west side westward and on the east side eastward,
matching one of the tribal portions in length from the western border
to the eastern border. 8 This land will be his possession in Israel. My
princes will no longer oppress my people, but they will let Israel’s
house have the land according to their tribes.
9 “This is what Lord Yahweh says: Enough, you princes of Israel!
Put away violence and plunder, and do what is just and right. Stop
evicting my people, declares Lord Yahweh. 10 Let your balances be
true, your dry measure true, and your liquid measure true.[i] 11 The
dry measure and the liquid measure are to be the same: the liquid
measure is to hold a tenth of a homer, and the dry measure a tenth of
a homer. Its standard will be set by the homer.[j] 12 The shekel is to be

twenty gerahs, about 0.4 ounce. Twenty shekels, twenty-five shekels, and fifteen shekels are to make your mina, about 1.5 pounds.[k]
13 "This is the contribution you are to set apart: one-sixtieth of your
wheat and one-sixtieth of your barley.[l] 14 The fixed share of oil is one-
hundredth of your oil.[m] 15 And one sheep from every flock of two
hundred from Israel's well-watered pastures.[n] All this serves for grain
offering, for burnt offering, and for fellowship sacrifices, to atone for
them, declares Lord Yahweh. 16 The land's whole population is to share
in giving this gift to Israel's prince. 17 On the prince will fall the duty of
burnt offering, grain offering, and drink offering at festivals, at new
moons, on Sabbaths, at all the appointed feasts of Israel's house. He
is to provide the sin offering, the grain offering, the burnt offering,
and the fellowship offerings to make atonement for Israel's house.
18 "Lord Yahweh says this: In the first month, on the first day of
the month (in March–April),[o] take an unblemished young bull and
cleanse the sanctuary. 19 The priest will take some of the blood of the
sin offering and put it on the temple's doorposts, on the four corners
of the altar's ledge, and on the posts of the gate of the inner court. 20
Repeat this on the month's seventh day[p] on behalf of whoever errs
without intent or is simple; thus you will make atonement for the
temple.
21 "On the fourteenth day of the first month (in March–April)[q] you
will celebrate the Passover, a feast of seven days,[r] when bread made
without yeast is to be eaten. 22 On that day the prince is to provide for
himself and for all the people of the land a bull for a sin offering. 23
During the seven days of the feast he is to provide as a burnt offering
to Yahweh seven bulls and seven rams without defect each day for
the seven days, and a male goat each day as a sin offering. 24 As a grain
offering he is to provide about 3/5 bushel of flour for each bull and
the same for each ram, with about a gallon of oil for each measure
of flour.[s]
25 "On the fifteenth day of the seventh month (in September–October),[t]
at the feast, he is to provide likewise through seven days, matching
the sin offering, the burnt offering, the grain offering, and the oil.

Notes

- a (45:1) Hebrew: “25,000” (about 13.1 km); “10,000” (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- b (45:1) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “twenty thousand.” Many interpreters follow the Greek, since vv. 3 and 5 give the priests and the Levites ten thousand each.
- c (45:1) For the land allotments in 45:1–8 and 48:8–35, Ezekiel gives the numbers without naming the unit. Some take the unit to be the reed (as in 42:16–20 and in the Greek of 45:1–2), which would make the figures six times larger. See the note at 40:5.
- d (45:2) Hebrew “five hundred by five hundred,” without a unit; if cubits, about 875 feet (263 m). The Greek has “five hundred reeds.” The open land is “fifty cubits,” about 87.5 feet (26 m).
- e (45:3) Hebrew: “25,000” (about 13.1 km); “10,000” (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- f (45:5) Hebrew: “25,000” (about 13.1 km); “10,000” (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- g (45:5) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “as their possession, twenty rooms.” The difference is a matter of a few letters.
- h (45:6) Hebrew: “5,000” (about 2.6 km); “25,000” (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- i (45:10) Hebrew “an honest ephah and an honest bath.” The ephah was a dry measure, and the bath a liquid measure of the same size, about 3/5 bushel or 6 gallons (22 liters). Ancient standards varied.
- j (45:11) Hebrew “The ephah and the bath are to be one measure, so that the bath holds a tenth of a homer and the ephah a tenth of a homer; its measure is to be according to the homer.” A homer was about 6 bushels (220 liters).
- k (45:12) A shekel was about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), and a gerah one-twentieth of a shekel; the mina here is sixty shekels, about 1.5 pounds (690 grams). The Greek has “your mina is to be five shekels, fifteen shekels, and fifty shekels.” Ancient standards varied.
- l (45:13) Hebrew “a sixth of an ephah from a homer of wheat, and a sixth of an ephah from a homer of barley.”
- m (45:14) Hebrew “a tenth of a bath from the kor; ten baths are a homer, for ten baths are a homer.” A kor was the same as a homer, about 6 bushels (220 liters).
- n (45:15) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “one sheep from the flock out of ten, as an offering from all the tribes of Israel.”
- o (45:18) The Hebrew has “in the first (month), on the first of the month.” The first month is Nisan in the spring-start calendar; this would fall in March–April.
- p (45:20) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “in the seventh month, on the first day of the month” (September–October).
- q (45:21) The Hebrew has “in the first (month), on the fourteenth day of the month,” Nisan in the spring-start calendar.

- r (45:21) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “a feast of weeks of days,” perhaps a copying slip for “seven days.”
- s (45:24) Hebrew “an ephah for the bull and an ephah for the ram, and a hin of oil for the ephah.” An ephah was about 3/5 bushel (22 liters), and a hin about 1 gallon (3.7 liters).
- t (45:25) The Hebrew has “in the seventh (month), on the fifteenth day of the month,” Tishri in the spring-start calendar. This is the Feast of Booths (Leviticus 23:34).

Chapter 46

1 “This is what Lord Yahweh says: The inner court’s east-facing gate
is to stay shut on the six working days, but on the Sabbath day it is to
be opened, and on the day of the new moon it is to be opened. 2 The
prince will come in from outside by way of the gate’s vestibule and
take his stand at the gate’s doorpost. The priests will present his burnt
offering and his fellowship offerings, and he will bow in worship on
the gate’s threshold and then go out; but the gate is not to be shut
until evening. 3 The people of the land will likewise bow in worship
before Yahweh at that gate’s entrance on Sabbaths and new moons. 4
The burnt offering the prince brings to Yahweh on the Sabbath day is
to be six lambs without defect and a ram without defect. 5 The grain
offering is to be about 3/5 bushel of flour with the ram, and with the
lambs whatever he is willing to give, with about a gallon of oil for
each 3/5 bushel.[a] 6 On the new moon it is to be a young bull without
defect, and six lambs and a ram, all without defect. 7 With the bull
he is to provide a grain offering of about 3/5 bushel, with the ram
the same, and with the lambs as much as he can afford, with about
a gallon of oil for each 3/5 bushel.[b] 8 Whenever the prince comes in,
his route is through the vestibule of the gate, and by that route he
departs.
9 “When the people of the land come before Yahweh at the appointed
feasts, whoever enters by the north gate to worship must leave by
the south gate, and whoever enters by the south gate must leave by
the north gate. No one is to go back through the gate he came in by;
each must go straight out ahead.[c] 10 As for the prince, he will be in
their midst: in with them as they enter, out with them as they leave.[d]

11 At the festivals and the appointed feasts the grain offering is to be
about 3/5 bushel with a bull and the same with a ram, and with the
lambs whatever he is willing to give, with about a gallon of oil for
each 3/5 bushel.
12 "When the prince provides a freewill offering for Yahweh, be it
burnt offering or fellowship sacrifices, someone must open for him
the east-facing gate, and he will present his burnt offering and
fellowship offerings as he does on the Sabbath day. Then he will go
out, and after he has gone out the gate is to be shut.
13 "You[e] are to provide a year-old lamb without defect each day as a
burnt offering to Yahweh; morning by morning you are to provide
it. 14 With it you are to provide a grain offering morning by morning:
about a gallon of flour, with about 1.25 quarts of oil to moisten the
fine flour.[f] This is a grain offering to Yahweh, a lasting statute for all
time. 15 So they[g] are to provide the lamb, the grain offering, and the
oil morning by morning as a regular burnt offering.
16 "Lord Yahweh says this: Suppose the prince makes a gift from his
own inheritance[h] to one of his sons; it will belong to his sons, and it
will be their possession by inheritance. 17 But if he gives a gift from
his inheritance to one of his servants, it will be the servant's until the
year of release;[i] then it will go back to the prince. His inheritance is
for his sons alone; it will remain theirs. 18 The prince must not take
any of the people's inheritance, driving them off their property. From
his own property he is to give his sons their inheritance, so that none
of my people will be scattered from their property."
19 Then he brought me through the entrance at the side of the gate to
the holy rooms facing north, which belonged to the priests. There I
saw a place at the far western end.[j] 20 He told me, "Here the priests will
boil the guilt offering and the sin offering, and here they will bake
the grain offering, so that nothing has to be carried out into the outer
courtyard, where it would transmit holiness to the people."
21 Next he took me out into the outer court and walked me around to
its four corners, and in each corner of the court there was a smaller
court. 22 In the four corners of the court were enclosed[k] courts, 70
feet long and 52.5 feet wide;[l] all four corner courts[m] were the same

size. 23 A row of stonework ran around each of the four, and hearths
for cooking were made under the rows all around. 24 He said to me,
“These are the kitchens where those who serve the temple will boil
the people’s sacrifices.”

Notes

- a (46:5) Hebrew “an ephah for the ram … and a hin of oil for the ephah.” An ephah was about 3/5 bushel (22 liters), and a hin about 1 gallon (3.7 liters). Ancient standards varied. The same measures are used in vv. 7 and 11.
- b (46:7) The Greek has “and a hin of oil for the cake.”
- c (46:9) So the Hebrew margin and the Greek; the written Hebrew text has “they must go out.”
- d (46:10) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “and when they go out, they will go out.”
- e (46:13) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “he.” The Greek also lacks “morning by morning” here and has “in the morning.”
- f (46:14) Hebrew “a sixth of an ephah, and a third of a hin of oil,” about 3.7 liters of flour and 1.2 liters of oil.
- g (46:15) So the Hebrew; the Greek has “you.”
- h (46:16) So the Greek; the Hebrew has “it is his inheritance.”
- i (46:17) Hebrew deror, the year of liberty, the Jubilee (Leviticus 25:10).
- j (46:19) The Greek has “a place set apart.”
- k (46:22) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain; the Greek has “small.”
- l (46:22) Hebrew: “40” (about 21 m); “30” (about 16 m); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- m (46:22) The Hebrew word here is marked with dots in the traditional text, which may indicate doubt; the meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 47

1 He brought me back to the temple’s entrance, and I saw water
flowing out from beneath the temple’s threshold toward the east,
since the temple faced east. The water was running down from under
the south side of the temple, south of the altar. 2 Then he led me out
through the north gate and around by the outside route to the outer
gate facing east, and I saw the water trickling out from the south side.
3 As the man went out eastward with a measuring line in hand, he
measured off 1,750 feet and led me through the water,[a] and it came
up to my ankles. 4 He measured off another 1,750 feet[b] and led me
through, and the water reached my knees.[c] He measured off another
1,750 feet and led me through, and it reached my waist. 5 Again he

measured off 1,750 feet, and by then it had become a stream too much for me to ford; the water had swelled into swimming depth, a torrent beyond any wading. 6 "Son of man," he said, "have you taken this in?" After that he walked me back to the edge of the river. 7 When I came back, I saw a great many trees along the bank, on both sides of the river. 8 He said to me, "Out to the eastern district these waters stream, descending into the Arabah;[d] once they pour into the sea, the sea of foul water,[e] its water turns wholesome. 9 Wherever the river[f] goes, every living creature that swarms there will live. There will be a great abundance of fish, since these waters arrive there and the brine is healed; everything will live wherever the river goes. 10 Fishermen will stand beside it from En-gedi[g] as far as En-eglaim;[h] it will be a place where nets are spread to dry. Its fish will be of many kinds, like the fish of the Great Sea,[i] very many. 11 But its marshes and pools will not be made fresh; they will be left for salt. 12 By the river, on both of its banks, all kinds of fruit trees will grow. Their leaves will never wither and their fruit will never run out. Every month they will produce new fruit, because the water for them flows out of the sanctuary. Their fruit will be for food and their leaves for healing."

13 This is what Lord Yahweh says: "These[j] are the boundaries by which you are to divide the land as an inheritance among the twelve tribes of Israel, with Joseph receiving two portions.[k] 14 You are to share it equally, each the same as his brother. I raised my hand in oath to give it to your ancestors, and this land will fall to you as your inheritance. 15 "This is the land's boundary. Northward, starting at the Great Sea, it follows the Hethlon road to Lebo-hamath[l] and Zedad,[m] 16 Berothah and Sibraim (which lie on the boundary between Damascus and Hamath), reaching as far as Hazer-hatticon,[n] by the border of Hauran. 17 So the boundary will run from the sea to Hazar-enon,[o] with the territory of Damascus and the territory of Hamath lying to the north. This is[p] the north side. 18 "On the east side the line runs between Hauran and Damascus, and along the Jordan between Gilead and the land of Israel, from the northern border down to the eastern sea and as far as Tamar.[q] This is the east side. 19 "The southern side will run southward from Tamar to the waters of Meribath-kadesh,[r] and then

follow the Wadi of Egypt[s] to the Great Sea. That is the southern side, facing the Negev. 20 "On the west side the Great Sea is the boundary up to a point opposite Lebo-hamath. This is the west side.
21 "You are to divide this land among yourselves by the tribes of Israel.
22 You are to allot it by lot as an inheritance for yourselves and for the foreigners who live among you and have had children among you. They are to count as natives among the Israelites, receiving shares by lot together with you within Israel's tribes. 23 In whatever tribe a foreigner lives, there you are to give him his inheritance," declares Lord Yahweh.

Notes

- a (47:3) Hebrew: 1,000 cubits (about 525 m).
- b (47:4) Hebrew "a thousand," that is, 1,000 cubits (about 525 m). So also in v. 5.
- c (47:4) The Greek has "thighs."
- d (47:8) The Arabah is the deep rift valley of the Jordan and the Dead Sea.
- e (47:8) The Hebrew of this phrase is difficult, perhaps "to the sea of the waters brought out"; the Greek has "to the outlet of the water." The sea is the Dead Sea.
- f (47:9) So the Greek; the Hebrew has "two rivers."
- g (47:10) En-gedi means "spring of the young goat." It is an oasis on the west shore of the Dead Sea.
- h (47:10) En-eglaim means "spring of two calves." Its location is uncertain.
- i (47:10) That is, the Mediterranean.
- j (47:13) So the Greek and some ancient witnesses; the Hebrew has an unusual word, probably a scribal slip for "this."
- k (47:13) Hebrew "Joseph, portions," that is, two shares for Ephraim and Manasseh.
- l (47:15) Lebo-hamath means "the entrance of Hamath." The Hebrew order is "Hethlon, to come to Zedad, Hamath"; the reading here follows 48:1. The Greek has very different forms of these names.
- m (47:15) Zedad probably means "side" or "slope." Here begins a list of northern places whose locations are mostly uncertain.
- n (47:16) Hazer-hatticon means "the middle village."
- o (47:17) Hazar-enon means "village of springs."
- p (47:17) So the Greek; the Hebrew has "and." So also in vv. 18 and 19.
- q (47:18) So the Greek; the Hebrew has "you will measure." Tamar means "palm tree"; the Greek translates it "the city of palm trees."
- r (47:19) Meribath-kadesh means "the quarrel at Kadesh" (Numbers 20:13; 27:14).
- s (47:19) The Hebrew has only "the wadi" here; it is the stream that marks the border with Egypt (Numbers 34:5).

Chapter 48

1 “These are the tribes by name. At the far north, beside the Hethlon
road to Lebo-hamath, as far as Hazar-enan[a] at Damascus’s border,
Hamath lying northward, running from the east side to the west side,[b]
Dan will have one portion. 2 Asher’s share comes next, bordering Dan,
and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 3 Naphtali’s share
comes next, bordering Asher, and stretches from the eastern edge
to the western. 4 Manasseh’s share comes next, bordering Naphtali,
and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 5 Ephraim’s share
comes next, bordering Manasseh, and stretches from the eastern edge
to the western. 6 Reuben’s share comes next, bordering Ephraim, and
stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 7 Judah’s share comes
next, bordering Reuben, and stretches from the eastern edge to the
western.

8 “Bordering the territory of Judah, running from the east side to the
west side, will be the sacred district that you are to set aside. It will
be about 8.3 miles wide[c] and as long as any of the tribal sections from
east to west, and the sanctuary will stand in the center of it. 9 The
contribution you set apart for Yahweh is to be about 8.3 miles long
and about 3.3 miles[d] wide.[e] 10 This holy contribution will belong to the
priests. It will measure about 8.3 miles on the north, about 3.3 miles
in width on the west, about 3.3 miles in width on the east, and about
8.3 miles on the south,[f] with Yahweh’s sanctuary in the middle of it.
11 It is for the consecrated priests, the sons of Zadok, who faithfully
guarded what I entrusted to them and refused to wander off with the
Israelites, unlike the Levites who wandered. 12 It will be their own
special contribution out of the land’s contribution, most holy, next to
the Levites’ territory.

13 “Alongside the priests’ territory the Levites will have a portion
about 8.3 miles long and about 3.3 miles wide. The whole length will
be about 8.3 miles and the width about 3.3 miles.[gh] 14 None of it may
be sold or exchanged, and this choicest part of the land must not pass
to others,[i] for it is holy to Yahweh.

15 “The remaining strip, about 1.7 miles wide and about 8.3 miles long,[j]
will be for common use by the city, for homes and for open land.

The city will stand in the middle of it. 16 These are its dimensions: the north side about 1.5 miles, the south side about 1.5 miles,[k] the east side about 1.5 miles, and the west side about 1.5 miles.[l] 17 The city's open land will be about 438 feet on the north, about 438 feet on the south, about 438 feet on the east, and about 438 feet on the west.[m] 18 What remains of the length alongside the holy contribution will be about 3.3 miles on the east and about 3.3 miles on the west.[n] It will lie alongside the holy contribution, and its produce will be food for the city's workers. 19 The city's workers, drawn from all the tribes of Israel, will farm it. 20 The whole contribution will be a square, about 8.3 miles on each side.[o] You are to set apart the holy contribution together with the city's property.[p]

21 "What remains on both sides of the holy contribution and the city's property will belong to the prince. It will extend east from the about 8.3 miles of the contribution to the eastern border, and west from the about 8.3 miles to the western border,[q] alongside the tribal portions; it will belong to the prince. The holy contribution, with the temple's sanctuary, will be in the middle of it. 22 So the Levites' property and the city's property will lie in the middle of what belongs to the prince; the prince's land will lie between Judah's territory and Benjamin's territory.

23 "As for the rest of the tribes: from the east side to the west side, Benjamin will have one portion. 24 Simeon's share comes next, bordering Benjamin, and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 25 Issachar's share comes next, bordering Simeon, and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 26 Zebulun's share comes next, bordering Issachar, and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 27 Gad's share comes next, bordering Zebulun, and stretches from the eastern edge to the western. 28 The southern boundary of Gad's territory will run from Tamar to the waters of Meribath-kadesh, and then follow the Wadi of Egypt to the Great Sea. 29 "This is the land you will allot to the tribes of Israel as their possession, and those are their shares," declares Lord Yahweh.

30 "These are the city's exits. On the north side, measuring about 1.5 miles,[r] 31 the city's gates will be named for the tribes of Israel: three

gates on the north, one for Reuben, one for Judah, and one for Levi.
32 On the east side, about 1.5 miles long,[s] there will be three gates:
one for Joseph, one for Benjamin, and one for Dan. 33 On the south
side, measuring about 1.5 miles,[t] there will be three gates: one for
Simeon, one for Issachar, and one for Zebulun. 34 On the west side,
about 1.5 miles long,[u] there will be three gates: one for Gad, one for
Asher, and one for Naphtali. 35 The distance around the city will be
about 6 miles.[v] And from that day on, the city's name will be Yahweh-
shammah, Yahweh Is There."[w]

Notes

- a (48:1) Hazar-enan, also spelled Hazar-enon (47:17), means "village of springs."
- b (48:1) So some ancient witnesses; the Hebrew has "and it will be his: the east side, the sea," which seems disordered.
- c (48:8) Hebrew: "25,000" (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- d (48:9) Hebrew: "25,000" (about 13.1 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- e (48:9) So the Hebrew; the Greek has "25,000 wide." Some scholars read "20,000," counting the Levites' strip in v. 13.
- f (48:10) Hebrew: "25,000" (about 13.1 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); "25,000" (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- g (48:13) Hebrew: "25,000" (about 13.1 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); "25,000" (about 13.1 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- h (48:13) So the Hebrew; the Greek ends "and the width 20,000."
- i (48:14) So the Hebrew margin; the written Hebrew text has "must not cause to pass."
- j (48:15) Hebrew: "5,000" (about 2.6 km); "25,000" (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- k (48:16) So the Hebrew margin and the Greek; the written Hebrew text repeats "five."
- l (48:16) Hebrew: "4,500" (about 2.4 km); "4,500" (about 2.4 km); "4,500" (about 2.4 km); "4,500" (about 2.4 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- m (48:17) Hebrew: "250" (about 131 m); "250" (about 131 m); "250" (about 131 m); "250" (about 131 m); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- n (48:18) Hebrew: "10,000" (about 5.3 km); "10,000" (about 5.3 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- o (48:20) Hebrew: "25,000" (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.

- p (48:20) Hebrew “you are to set apart the holy contribution with the city’s property as a fourth.” The meaning is uncertain; the Greek has “you shall separate again part of it.”
- q (48:21) Hebrew: “25,000” (about 13.1 km); “25,000” (about 13.1 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- r (48:30) Hebrew: “4,500” (about 2.4 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- s (48:32) Hebrew: “4,500” (about 2.4 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- t (48:33) Hebrew: “4,500” (about 2.4 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- u (48:34) Hebrew: “4,500” (about 2.4 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- v (48:35) Hebrew: “18,000” (about 9.5 km); the unit is not stated but is probably the long cubit.
- w (48:35) Hebrew YHWH shammah. The Greek reads the same consonants differently: “from the day it comes to be, that will be its name.”

Daniel

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the third year of the reign of Jehoiakim king of Judah,[a] Nebuchad-
nezzar king of Babylon came to Jerusalem and laid siege to it. 2 And
the Lord gave Jehoiakim king of Judah into his hand, together with
part of the vessels of God's house. These he brought to the land
of Shinar,[b] to the house of his god, placing the vessels in his god's
treasure house.
3 Then the king told Ashpenaz, the chief of his court officials,[c] to bring
some of the Israelites, both of the royal family and of the nobility—
4 young men without any defect, good-looking, skilled in every kind
of wisdom, well informed, quick to understand, and able to serve in
the king's palace—and to teach them the literature and language of
the Chaldeans.[d] 5 The king allotted them a daily portion of the royal
food and of his own wine. Their education was to last three years,
after which they would stand before the king.
6 Among them, from the people of Judah, were Daniel, Hananiah,
Mishael, and Azariah.[e] 7 The chief official gave them new names:
to Daniel he gave the name Belteshazzar, to Hananiah Shadrach, to
Mishael Meshach, and to Azariah Abednego.[f]
8 But Daniel made up his mind not to defile himself with the royal food
or with the king's wine, and he sought leave from the chief official not
to defile himself. 9 God had caused the chief official to show Daniel
favor and compassion, 10 and the chief official told Daniel, "I fear my
lord the king, who has appointed what you eat and drink. If he sees
your faces thinner than those of the youths of your own age, why
should that be? You would put my head in danger with the king." 11
Then Daniel spoke to the steward[g] whom the chief official had put
in charge of Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah: 12 "Test your
servants, I beg you, for ten days. Have them give us vegetables to eat

and water to drink. 13 Then look at our faces and at the faces of the youths who eat the royal food, and treat your servants as you find." 14 So he consented to them in this matter and proved them for ten days. 15 When the ten days were over, their faces looked better and they were fuller in flesh than any of the youths who ate the royal food. 16 From then on the steward kept taking away their food and the wine meant for them to drink and gave them vegetables.

17 To these four young men God gave knowledge and skill in all literature and wisdom, and Daniel could understand visions and dreams of every kind. 18 At the end of the time the king had set for them to be brought in, the chief official brought them before Nebuchadnezzar. 19 The king talked with them, and among them all no one was found equal to Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. So they entered the king's service. 20 In every matter of wisdom and understanding about which the king asked them, he found them ten times better than all the magicians and enchanters in his whole kingdom. 21 Daniel continued there until the first year of King Cyrus.[h]

Notes

- a (1:1) That is, 605 BC. Jeremiah 25:1 and 46:2 date Nebuchadnezzar's first year to Jehoiakim's fourth year; the difference probably reflects different ways of counting a king's first year (Babylonian versus Judean reckoning).
- b (1:2) An ancient name for Babylonia (compare Genesis 10:10; 11:2).
- c (1:3) Hebrew saris, often "eunuch," but also used of high court officials in general; likewise in verses 7–11 and 18.
- d (1:4) In Daniel "Chaldeans" usually means a class of learned men skilled in astrology and divination, as well as the people of Babylonia.
- e (1:6) The Hebrew names mean: Daniel, "God is my judge"; Hananiah, "Yahweh has been gracious"; Mishael, probably "Who is what God is?"; Azariah, "Yahweh has helped."
- f (1:7) The new names are Babylonian. Belteshazzar probably represents Akkadian Balaṭ-šarri-uṣur, "protect the king's life" (Daniel 4:8 connects it with the god Bel). Shadrach and Meshach are of uncertain meaning. Abednego probably means "servant of Nego," perhaps a deliberate alteration of Nabu, the Babylonian god of wisdom. In the Aramaic chapters the king and others usually call Daniel by his Babylonian name.
- g (1:11) Hebrew melzar, probably a title ("guardian, steward") rather than a personal name; the KJV took it as a name, "Melzar."

- h (1:21) 539 BC, when Cyrus of Persia took Babylon. Daniel 10:1 records a vision in Cyrus's third year.

Chapter 2

1 In the second year of his reign,[a] Nebuchadnezzar had dreams; his
spirit was troubled, and his sleep left him. 2 So the king gave orders
to summon the magicians, the enchanters, the sorcerers, and the
Chaldeans to tell the king his dreams. They came in and stood before
the king. 3 The king said to them, "I have had a dream, and my spirit
is troubled to know what the dream was." 4 Then the Chaldeans spoke
to the king in Aramaic:[b] "O king, live forever! Tell your servants
the dream, and we will give its interpretation." 5 The king replied to
the Chaldeans, "The matter is settled on my part:[c] unless you make
known to me both the dream and what it means, you will be cut to
pieces and your houses made a dunghill. 6 But if you tell me the dream
and its interpretation, you will receive from me gifts and rewards
and great honor. So tell me the dream and its interpretation." 7 They
answered a second time, "Let the king tell his servants the dream,
and we will give its interpretation." 8 The king answered, "I know for
certain that you are trying to gain time, because you see that my
decision is firm: 9 Unless you make the dream known to me, there
is just one law for you. You have plotted to speak lying and corrupt
words before me until the times change. So tell me the dream, and I
will know that you can show me its interpretation." 10 The Chaldeans
replied before the king, "No one on earth can show what the king
demands! No king, however great and mighty, has asked anything
like this of any magician, enchanter, or Chaldean. 11 What the king
asks is too difficult, and there is no one who can reveal it to the king
except the gods, whose dwelling is not with mortals." 12 At this the
king became furious and very angry and ordered all the wise men of
Babylon to be destroyed. 13 The order was issued that the wise men
be executed, and officers searched for Daniel and his friends so they
could be executed too.

14 Daniel responded with tact and good judgment to Arioch, commander of the royal guard, who had set out to execute Babylon's wise men.
15 He said to Arioch, the king's captain, "Why is the king's decree so urgent?" And Arioch told Daniel the matter.
16 Daniel went in and requested of the king that he would grant him time to show the king the interpretation.
17 Then Daniel went to his house and told the matter to Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, his companions,
18 and urged them to ask for mercy from the God of heaven concerning this mystery, so that Daniel and his companions would not be destroyed with the rest of the wise men of Babylon.
19 Then the mystery was revealed to Daniel in a vision of the night, and Daniel blessed the God of heaven.
20 Daniel spoke and said:
"Blessed be the name of God
forever and ever,
for wisdom and might are his.
21 He changes times and seasons;
he removes kings and sets up kings;
he gives wisdom to the wise
and knowledge to those who have understanding.
22 He uncovers deep and secret matters;
he knows what is hidden in darkness,
and light lives with him.
23 God of my ancestors,
I thank you and praise you,
because you gave me wisdom and strength,
and now you have shown me what we begged of you;
you have revealed to us the king's concern."
24 Daniel then went in to Arioch, the man the king had appointed to execute Babylon's wise men. He said to him, "The wise men of Babylon must not be killed. Bring me before the king, and the meaning of his dream is what I will give him." 25 Arioch hurried Daniel in before the king and told him, "I have found among the exiles of

Judah a man who will make the interpretation known to the king."
26 The king said to Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar, "Are you
able to make known to me the dream I saw and its interpretation?"
27 Daniel replied to the king, "The mystery the king is asking about is
something no wise man, sorcerer, magician or astrologer can explain
to the king. 28 But there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries,
and he has made known to King Nebuchadnezzar what will happen
in the latter days. Your dream and the visions of your head as you
lay on your bed were these: 29 As for you, O king, as you lay on your
bed, your thoughts turned to what would happen after this, and the
Revealer of mysteries has made known to you what is to come. 30 But
as for me, this mystery was not revealed to me because of any wisdom
in me greater than that of all living, but in order that the king might
be told the interpretation, and that you might know the thoughts of
your heart.
31 "You were watching, O king, and there before you was a great statue.
That statue was huge and its brilliance extraordinary; it stood in front
of you, and its appearance was terrifying. 32 The head of this statue
was of fine gold, its chest and arms of silver, its belly and thighs of
bronze, 33 its legs were iron, and its feet part iron and part clay.[d] 34 You
kept watching until a stone was cut out without hands. It struck the
image on its iron and clay feet and broke them in pieces. 35 At that
moment the iron, clay, bronze, silver and gold were broken to pieces
together and became like the chaff on a summer threshing floor. The
wind carried them off, leaving no trace of them. But the rock that hit
the statue grew into an immense mountain and covered the entire
earth.
36 "Such was the dream; its interpretation we will now tell before
the king. 37 You, O king, are the king of kings, to whom the God of
heaven has given the kingdom, the power, the might, and the glory.
38 Wherever people live, he has given into your hand the beasts of the
field and the birds of the sky, and has made you ruler over them all.
You are that head of gold. 39 After you another kingdom will arise,
inferior to yours, and then a third kingdom, of bronze, which will
rule over the whole earth. 40 After that, a fourth kingdom will arise, as

hard as iron; iron crushes and breaks everything, and like iron that smashes, this kingdom will crush and break all the others.[e] 41 And as you saw the feet and the toes, part potter's clay and part iron, it will be a divided kingdom; yet some of the iron's firmness will be in it, since you saw iron mixed with miry clay. 42 As the toes of the feet were partly iron and partly clay, so the kingdom will be partly strong and partly brittle. 43 And as you saw the iron mixed with miry clay, they will mingle with one another by marriage,[f] but they will not cling together, even as iron does not mix with clay. 44 In the days of those kings the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that will never be destroyed; its rule will not pass to another people. It will break in pieces and make an end of all these kingdoms, but it will itself stand forever— 45 It is as you saw: a rock was chiseled from a mountain, though no human hand was involved, and it pulverized the iron, bronze, clay, silver and gold. The great God is informing the king about what will occur afterward. The dream is true, and its interpretation can be trusted."

46 Then King Nebuchadnezzar bowed down with his face to the ground and honored Daniel, and he gave orders to present a grain offering and incense to him. 47 The king answered Daniel, "Truly your God is God of gods and Lord of kings and the revealer of mysteries, since you could reveal this mystery." 48 The king then gave Daniel a high position and many generous gifts. He made him governor of the entire province of Babylon and head over all of Babylon's wise men. 49 Daniel asked the king to appoint Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego to manage the province of Babylon, and the king did so; Daniel himself remained at the king's court.[g]

Notes

- a (2:1) About 603 BC. This seems to fall within the three years of training in 1:5; by inclusive reckoning, part-years may have been counted as whole years, and 1:18–20 need not come after 2:1 in time.
- b (2:4) Hebrew 'aramit, "in Aramaic." From here through 7:28 the book is written in Aramaic, the common language of the Babylonian and Persian empires; at 8:1 it returns to Hebrew. The word "in Aramaic" may originally have been a scribal notice marking the change of language. The Qumran fragments that cover these passages show the same switches of language. Why the book is bilingual is

debated; the Aramaic section (2:4b–7:28) is arranged as a unit, with chapters 2 and 7 (four kingdoms), 3 and 6 (deliverance from death), and 4 and 5 (the humbling of kings) matching each other.

- c (2:5) Or "The word has gone out from me." The Aramaic azda is a Persian loanword, "certain, publicly known."
- d (2:33) Aramaic khasaf, baked clay or earthenware, as in potters' ware (verse 41); likewise in verses 34–35 and 41–45.
- e (2:40) The identity of the four kingdoms is much discussed. The traditional Jewish and Christian view is Babylon, Media-Persia, Greece, and Rome; many modern scholars hold Babylon, Media, Persia, and Greece (Alexander and his successors), which fits the later visions (compare 5:28, 31; 8:20–21). Compare chapter 7.
- f (2:43) Aramaic "by the seed of men," probably referring to marriage alliances between ruling houses (compare 11:6, 17).
- g (2:49) Aramaic "in the gate of the king," the place of royal administration.

Chapter 3

1 King Nebuchadnezzar made a statue of gold, about 90 feet high and 9
feet wide,[a] and set it up on the plain of Dura in the province of Baby-
lon. 2 Then King Nebuchadnezzar sent to gather the satraps, prefects,
governors, counselors, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and every
official of the provinces, that they should come to the dedication of
the image that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.[b] 3 Then the satraps,
prefects, governors, counselors, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and
every official of the provinces gathered to the dedication of the image
that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up, and they stood before the
image that Nebuchadnezzar had set up. 4 Then the herald called out
loudly, "People of every nation and language, you are commanded:
5 that whenever you hear the sound of horn, pipe, lyre, trigon, harp,
bagpipe,[c] and all kinds of music, you shall fall down and worship
the golden image that King Nebuchadnezzar has set up. 6 Whoever
does not fall down and worship shall in that same hour be cast into
the midst of a burning fiery furnace." 7 So as soon as all the peoples
heard the sound of the horn, pipe, lyre, trigon, harp, and every kind
of music, all the people of every nation and language fell down and
worshiped the statue of gold that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.
8 At that time certain Chaldeans came near and maliciously accused
the Jews.[d] 9 They said to King Nebuchadnezzar, "O king, live forever! 10

You, O king, have made a decree that every man who hears the sound
of horn, pipe, lyre, trigon, harp, bagpipe, and all kinds of music shall
fall down and worship the golden image, 11 and whoever does not
fall down and worship shall be cast into the midst of a burning fiery
furnace. 12 There are certain Jews whom you appointed over the affairs
of the province of Babylon: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. These
men, O king, have not regarded you; your gods they do not serve, and
the golden image you set up they do not worship."
13 Then Nebuchadnezzar, in a furious rage, ordered Shadrach, Me-
shach, and Abednego to be brought in. So these men were brought
before the king. 14 Nebuchadnezzar spoke to them: "Is it on purpose,
Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, that you do not serve my gods
nor worship the golden image I have set up? 15 Now, if you are
prepared, then when you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither,
lyre, harp, pipes and every other instrument, you must bow down
and worship the statue I made; that will be fine. But if you refuse to
worship, you will be thrown at once into the blazing furnace. And
what god can rescue you from my power?" 16 Shadrach, Meshach, and
Abednego answered the king, "Nebuchadnezzar, we have no need
to give you an answer on this matter. 17 If it is so,[e] our God whom
we serve is able to rescue us from the blazing fiery furnace, and he
will rescue us from your hand, O king. 18 But even if he does not,
you should know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or
worship the golden statue you set up."
19 Then Nebuchadnezzar was filled with rage, and his face was
distorted with anger at Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. He gave
orders to heat the furnace seven times hotter than it was usually
heated, 20 and he ordered some of the strongest men in his army to
bind Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego and throw them into the
blazing fiery furnace. 21 So these men were bound in their cloaks, their
trousers, their caps, and their other garments,[f] and were thrown into
the blazing fiery furnace. 22 The king's command was so strict and the
furnace so extremely hot that the flames killed the men who lifted up
Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego. 23 And these three men, Shadrach,

Meshach, and Abednego, fell bound into the middle of the blazing fiery furnace.[g]

24 Then King Nebuchadnezzar leaped to his feet in astonishment.
"Weren't there three men that we bound and threw into the fire?"
he asked his counselors. "Certainly, Your Majesty," they answered.
25 He said, "Look, I see four men walking around loose in the fire,
and they are not hurt at all; and the fourth looks like a son of the
gods."[h] 26 Nebuchadnezzar approached the door of the blazing furnace
and called, "Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, you servants of the
Most High God, come out and come here!" Shadrach, Meshach and
Abednego then came out of the fire. 27 And the satraps, prefects,
governors, and the king's counselors gathered and saw these men,
that the fire had no power over their bodies; not a hair of their heads
was singed, their cloaks were unchanged, and no smell of fire had
come upon them.

28 Nebuchadnezzar declared, "Praise to the God of Shadrach, Meshach
and Abednego, who sent his angel and saved his servants! They
trusted in him, disobeyed the king's order, and risked their lives
rather than serve or worship any god other than their own God. 29 I
therefore decree that any person of any people, nation or language
who speaks against the God of Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego will
be cut into pieces and his house reduced to a heap of ruins, since no
other god can rescue people in this way." 30 Then the king promoted
Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego in the province of Babylon.

Notes

- a (3:1) Aramaic "sixty cubits high and six cubits wide" (about 27 by 2.7 meters). The tall, narrow proportions suggest an image on a high pedestal or an obelisk-like monument. The Septuagint dates the event to Nebuchadnezzar's eighteenth year (compare Jeremiah 52:29).
- b (3:2) Several of these titles are Persian loanwords, and the exact functions of some are uncertain.
- c (3:5) The identification of several instruments is uncertain. Three of the names (qitharos "lyre," pesanterin "harp," and sumponyah, perhaps "bagpipe" or "drum," or "playing together") are Greek loanwords.
- d (3:8) Aramaic "ate the pieces of the Jews," an idiom for slander or malicious accusation.

- e (3:17) Or "If our God whom we serve is able to rescue us, he will rescue us…" The Aramaic can be read either way.
- f (3:21) The exact meaning of these words for clothing is uncertain.
- g (3:23) At this point the Greek versions (both the Old Greek and Theodotion) add 68 verses not found in the Hebrew-Aramaic text: the Prayer of Azariah, a short prose account of the fire and of the angel who came down into the furnace, and the Song of the Three Young Men ("Bless the Lord, all you works of the Lord…"). These additions are part of Daniel in Catholic and Orthodox Bibles and appear among the Apocrypha in Protestant Bibles. They will be translated in the CJT's Apocrypha, together with the other Greek additions to Daniel, Susanna and Bel and the Dragon.
- h (3:25) Or "a divine being." In Aramaic "son of the gods" means a being of the divine class; verse 28 calls him God's "angel." The KJV's "the Son of God" reads the phrase in the light of later Christian interpretation.

Chapter 4

1 King Nebuchadnezzar, to all peoples, nations, and languages that dwell in all the earth:[a] May your peace abound!

2 It has seemed good to me to make known the signs and wonders that the Most High God has done for me.

3 How great are his signs,
how mighty his wonders!
His kingdom is an everlasting kingdom,
and his dominion is from generation to generation.

4 I, Nebuchadnezzar, was living at ease in my house, flourishing in my palace.

5 I saw a dream that made me afraid; the imaginings on my bed and the visions of my head alarmed me.

6 So I issued a decree that all the wise men of Babylon should be brought in before me to make known to me the dream's interpretation.

7 Then the magicians, sorcerers, Chaldeans and astrologers came in. I described the dream to them, but they could not tell me what it meant.

8 Finally Daniel came before me—his name is Belteshazzar, after the name of my god,[b] and he has the spirit of the holy gods in him—and I described the dream to him:

9 “Belteshazzar, chief of the magicians, I know that the spirit of the
holy gods is in you and that nothing puzzling is beyond you. Listen
to the visions I saw in my dream, and give me the interpretation.
10 These were the visions in my mind as I lay in bed:
I looked, and there in the middle of the earth stood a tree,
and it was very tall.
11 The tree grew large and strong,
its top reached to heaven,
and it could be seen to the ends of the whole earth.
12 Its leaves were lovely and its fruit abundant,
and in it was food for all.
Under it the beasts of the field found shade,
in its branches the birds of the sky lived,
and from it all flesh was fed.
13 “In the visions of my head upon my bed I watched, and look—a
watcher, a holy one,[c] descending from heaven.
14 He called out loudly, saying:
‘Hew the tree down and cut away its branches,
shake off its foliage and scatter its fruit.
Let the animals run from beneath it,
the birds from its boughs.
15 But leave the stump with its roots in the ground,
wrapped in a band of iron and bronze,
among the fresh grass of the field.
Let him be soaked with the dew of the sky,
and let him share the plants of the earth with the animals.
16 Let his mind be changed from a man’s,
and let the mind of a beast be given to him,
and let seven times[d] pass over him.
17 This sentence is announced by the watchers,
this verdict is given by the holy ones,
so that everyone alive will recognize
that the Most High is ruler over human kingdoms,
gives them to anyone he chooses,
and puts the lowest of people in charge of them.’

18 This is the dream I, King Nebuchadnezzar, have seen. You, Belteshazzar, declare its meaning, because all the wise men in my kingdom
are unable to make the interpretation known to me; but you can, for
a spirit of the holy gods is in you."
19 Then Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar, was dismayed for a
time, and his thoughts alarmed him. The king said, "Belteshazzar, let
neither the dream nor its meaning trouble you." Belteshazzar replied,
"My lord, would that the dream were for your haters, and its meaning
for your foes! 20 The tree that you saw grow great and strong, its top
reaching to heaven, visible to all the earth, 21 It had beautiful leaves
and plenty of fruit, with food on it for everyone; animals of the field
lived in its shade, and birds of the sky nested in its branches— 22 it is
you, O king, who have grown great and strong. Your greatness has
grown and reaches to heaven, and your dominion to the end of the
earth. 23 You saw a watcher, a holy one, coming down from heaven
and announcing, 'Chop down the tree and destroy it, but leave the
stump with its roots in the ground, wrapped in a band of iron and
bronze, among the fresh grass of the field; let it be soaked with the
dew of the sky and share the plants of the field with the animals, until
seven periods of time go by for him.' 24 Here is the interpretation, Your
Majesty: this is a decree of the Most High, and it concerns my lord
the king. 25 People will drive you away, and you will make your home
with the wild animals. You will graze on grass like cattle, with the
dew of the sky soaking you. Seven periods of time will go by over you
before you acknowledge that the Most High rules over the kingdoms
of humankind and hands them to whomever he chooses. 26 And as it
was commanded to leave the stump of the tree's roots, your kingdom
will be restored to you from the time you know that Heaven[e] rules. 27
Therefore, Your Majesty, please accept my advice: put an end to your
sins by doing what is right, and to your wrongdoing by being kind to
the poor. Then perhaps your well-being will last."
28 All this came upon King Nebuchadnezzar. 29 Twelve months later,
as he walked upon the royal palace of Babylon, 30 and the king said,
"Is not this great Babylon, which I have built as a royal residence by
the might of my power and for the glory of my majesty?" 31 While the

words were still in the king's mouth, a voice fell from heaven: "To you it is spoken, King Nebuchadnezzar: the kingdom has departed from you! 32 People will drive you away, and you will make your home with the wild animals. You will graze on grass like cattle. Seven periods of time will go by over you before you acknowledge that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of humankind and hands them to whomever he chooses." 33 Right at that moment the word about Nebuchadnezzar came true. He was driven away from people and ate grass like cattle, and his body was soaked with the dew of the sky, until his hair grew as long as eagle feathers and his nails like the claws of a bird.[f]

34 At the end of the days I, Nebuchadnezzar, raised my eyes to heaven, and my understanding came back to me. Then I blessed the Most High; I praised and honored the one who lives forever:

For his dominion is an everlasting dominion,
and his kingdom from generation to generation.

35 All who dwell on the earth are reckoned as nothing,
and he does according to his will in heaven's army
and among earth's inhabitants;
none can stay his hand
or ask him, "What are you doing?"

36 At that same time my understanding came back to me, and for the glory of my kingdom my majesty and brightness returned to me. My counselors and my nobles came looking for me; I was established again in my kingdom, and surpassing greatness was added to me.

37 Now I, Nebuchadnezzar, offer praise, glory and honor to the King of heaven. All that he does is true, his ways are just, and he has the power to humble those who walk in arrogance.

Notes

- a (4:1) Verses 1–3 are 3:31–33 in the Aramaic text, and verses 4–37 are 4:1–34. The Old Greek of chapter 4 is considerably longer and differently arranged, placing this proclamation at the end of the chapter; Theodotion follows the Aramaic.
- b (4:8) That is, Bel (Marduk), chief god of Babylon. The king connects the name with Bel by popular association (compare the note at 1:7).
- c (4:13) Aramaic ʿir, "wakeful one," a heavenly being who keeps watch; elsewhere in the Bible only in verses 17 and 23. The term became common in later Jewish writings such as 1 Enoch.

- d (4:16) Probably seven years (so the Old Greek), though the word means simply "periods of time."
- e (4:26) This is the only place in the Old Testament where "Heaven" stands for God, a usage common in later Judaism (compare "the kingdom of heaven" in Matthew).
- f (4:33) No Babylonian record mentions such an illness of Nebuchadnezzar. A fragmentary Aramaic text from Qumran, the Prayer of Nabonidus (4Q242), as reported tells of Nabonidus, the last king of Babylon, being stricken for seven years in Teima and being healed when a Jewish exile urged him to honor God. Many scholars think the story in Daniel is related to such a tradition.

Chapter 5

1 King Belshazzar[a] made a great feast for a thousand of his nobles,
and he drank wine in front of the thousand. 2 Under the influence
of the wine, Belshazzar gave an order to bring the gold and silver
vessels that his father Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple in
Jerusalem, so that the king, his nobles, his wives and his concubines
could drink from them. 3 So they brought in the golden vessels taken
from the temple, God's house at Jerusalem, and the king drank from
them, with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines. 4 While drinking
the wine, they praised the gods made of gold, silver, bronze, iron,
wood and stone.
5 Suddenly the fingers of a human hand appeared and began writing
on the plaster of the royal palace wall, across from the lampstand;
and the king watched the hand as it wrote. 6 Then the king's color
changed, and his thoughts alarmed him; the joints of his hips gave
way, and his knees knocked against each other. 7 The king shouted
for the sorcerers, Chaldeans and astrologers to be brought in. He told
Babylon's wise men, "Anyone who can read this inscription and ex-
plain it to me will be dressed in purple, have a gold chain placed on his
neck, and be made the third highest ruler in the kingdom."[b] 8 So all the
king's wise men came in, but none of them could read the inscription
or explain its meaning to the king. 9 So King Belshazzar was greatly
alarmed, his color changed, and his nobles were perplexed.
10 Because of what the king and his nobles had said, the queen[c] came
into the banquet house. The queen spoke: "O king, live forever!
Let not your thoughts alarm you, nor your color change. 11 There
is a man in your kingdom who has the spirit of the holy gods.

During your father's reign he showed brightness, understanding and
wisdom comparable to the wisdom of the gods, and your father
King Nebuchadnezzar appointed him chief of the magicians, sorcer-
ers, Chaldeans and astrologers—yes, your father the king did so— 12
since an excellent spirit, with knowledge and insight for interpreting
dreams, explaining riddles, and solving problems,[d] was found in him
—in Daniel, whom the king named Belteshazzar. Let Daniel be sum-
moned now, and he will declare the interpretation."
13 Then they brought Daniel in before the king, who said to him, "So
you are Daniel, one of the captives from Judah that my father the
king brought out of Judah? 14 I have heard of you, that a spirit of the
gods is in you, and that light and understanding and extraordinary
wisdom are found in you. 15 Just now the wise men, the enchanters,
were brought in before me to read this writing and make known to
me its interpretation, but they could not show the interpretation of
the matter. 16 But I have heard that you can give interpretations and
solve problems. Now if you can read the writing and make known to
me its interpretation, you will be clothed in purple, with a chain of
gold around your neck, and will rule as third in the kingdom."
17 Then Daniel answered before the king, "Keep your gifts for yourself,
and give your rewards to someone else. Nevertheless I will read the
writing to the king and make known to him the interpretation. 18
Your Majesty, the Most High God gave your father Nebuchadnezzar
a kingdom, greatness, glory and splendor. 19 Because of the greatness
God gave him, people of every nation and language shook with fear
in front of him. He put to death anyone he wished and spared anyone
he wished; he promoted anyone he wished and demoted anyone he
wished. 20 But when his heart was lifted up and his spirit grew hard
so that he acted proudly, he was brought down from his royal throne,
and his glory was taken from him. 21 He was expelled from human
company; his mind became like an animal's, and he lived among the
wild donkeys. He grazed on grass like cattle, with the dew of the
sky soaking his body, until he acknowledged that the Most High God
rules over the kingdoms of humankind and puts in charge whomever
he chooses. 22 And you, his son, Belshazzar, have not humbled your

heart, though you knew all this. 23 You have set yourself up against the Lord of heaven. The vessels from his house were brought to you, and with them you, your nobles, your wives and your concubines drank your wine. You sang praises to gods of silver, gold, bronze, iron, wood and stone, which neither see nor hear nor know; but the God who holds your very breath in his hand, and owns all your paths, you did not glorify. 24 That is why the hand was sent out from him, and this writing was written.

25 "This is the writing that was inscribed: MENE, MENE, TEKEL, and PARSIN.[e] 26 Here is what the words mean: MENE—God has numbered your kingdom and finished it. 27 TEKEL, you have been weighed in the scales and found lacking. 28 PERES, your kingdom is divided and given to the Medes and Persians."

29 Then at Belshazzar's command they clothed Daniel in purple, put a chain of gold around his neck, and proclaimed concerning him that he should rule as third in the kingdom. 30 That very night Belshazzar the Chaldean king was killed. 31 And Darius the Mede received the kingdom, being about sixty-two years old.[f]

Notes

- a (5:1) Belshazzar (Babylonian Bel-šarra-uṣur, "Bel, protect the king") was the son of Nabonidus, the last king of Babylon, and ruled as regent in Babylon during his father's long absence in Arabia. Nebuchadnezzar is called his "father" (verses 2, 11, 13, 18) in the sense of predecessor, as often in ancient usage. Babylon fell to the Persians in October 539 BC.
- b (5:7) That is, after Nabonidus and Belshazzar himself; or "as one of three rulers" (compare 6:2).
- c (5:10) Probably the queen mother, since the king's wives are already at the feast (verses 2–3).
- d (5:12) Aramaic "loosen knots," perhaps also an allusion to undoing spells; likewise in verse 16.
- e (5:25) These words are Aramaic names of weights or monetary units: the mina (about 1¼ pounds or 570 grams), the shekel (about 0.4 ounce or 11.5 grams), and half-minas (peres, plural parsin). Daniel reads them as verbs: mene, "numbered"; tekel, "weighed"; peres, "divided," with a further play on Paras, "Persia." The Old Greek and Theodotion and Josephus have only three words (mene, tekel, peres).
- f (5:31) This verse is 6:1 in the Aramaic text. Darius the Mede is not known from sources outside the Bible. He has been identified with Gubaru (Gobryas), Cyrus's governor of Babylon, or with Cyrus himself (reading 6:28 as "Darius, that is, Cyrus

the Persian"); many scholars think the book reflects a scheme in which a Median kingdom followed Babylon (compare 2:39; 7:5; 8:20).

Chapter 6

1 It pleased Darius to set over the kingdom a hundred and twenty satraps,[a] to be throughout the whole kingdom, 2 and over them three chief ministers, of whom Daniel was one, so that the satraps might give account to them and the king might suffer no loss. 3 Soon this Daniel was outperforming the other administrators and the satraps, because he had an outstanding spirit, and the king intended to appoint him over the entire kingdom.

4 Then the ministers and satraps tried to find a pretext against Daniel in regard to the kingdom, but they could find neither pretext nor fault, since he was trustworthy; no error or fault could be found in him. 5 So these men said, "We will find no pretext against this Daniel except in connection with the law of his God."

6 Then these ministers and satraps came thronging[b] to the king and said to him, "King Darius, live forever! 7 All the ministers of the kingdom, the prefects and satraps, the counselors and governors, have agreed that the king should issue a statute and make a firm prohibition: whoever asks a petition of any god or man for thirty days, except of you, O king, shall be cast into the den of lions. 8 Now, O king, establish the prohibition and sign the writing, that it may not be altered, by the law of the Medes and Persians, which is never repealed." 9 Therefore King Darius signed the document and the interdict.

10 When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went into his house. In his upper room he had windows open toward Jerusalem, and three times a day he knelt on his knees and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done before.[c] 11 Then these men came thronging and found Daniel making petition and supplication before his God. 12 Then they approached and spoke before the king concerning the king's prohibition: "Have you not signed a prohibition that anyone who asks a petition of any god or man within thirty days, except of you, O king, shall be cast into the den of lions?" The king

replied, “That is certain, by the law of the Medes and Persians, which
is never repealed.” 13 Then they said before the king, “That Daniel,
one of the exiles of Judah, has no regard for you, O king, nor for
the prohibition you signed; three times a day he makes his petition.”
14 When the king heard these words, he was much distressed, and
set his mind on delivering Daniel; and until the sun went down he
labored to rescue him. 15 Then the men rushed in to the king and told
him, “Remember, Your Majesty, that under the law of the Medes and
Persians no decree or edict the king issues can be altered.”
16 So the king commanded, and Daniel was brought and thrown into
the lions’ den. The king spoke to Daniel: “Your God, whom you serve
without ceasing, will deliver you!” 17 A stone was brought and laid
on the mouth of the den, and the king sealed it with his own signet
and with the signet of his nobles, so that nothing might be changed
concerning Daniel. 18 Then the king returned to his palace and passed
the night fasting; no diversions[d] were brought before him, and sleep
fled from him.
19 Then at dawn, at first light, the king arose and went in haste to the
den of lions. 20 When he drew near the den, he called to Daniel with
a voice full of anguish. The king said, “Daniel, servant of the living
God, your God whom you serve without ceasing—has he been able
to deliver you from the lions?” 21 Then Daniel said to the king, “O
king, live forever! 22 My God has sent his angel and closed the lions’
mouths, and they have not hurt me, for I was found blameless before
him; and before you too, O king, I have committed no crime.” 23 Then
the king was overjoyed and gave orders to lift Daniel up out of the
den. So Daniel was lifted out of the den, and no injury of any kind
was found on him, for he had trusted in his God. 24 Then the king gave
orders, and those who had maliciously accused Daniel[e] were brought
in and cast into the den of lions, together with their children and their
wives. Before they reached the floor of the den, the lions seized them
and crushed all their bones.
25 Then King Darius wrote to all the peoples, nations, and languages
that dwell in all the earth: “May your peace abound!

26 I issue a decree that throughout all the dominion of my kingdom
people shall tremble and fear before Daniel's God,
for he is the living God,
and he endures forever;
his kingdom is one that will not be destroyed,
and his rule will last to the end.
27 He rescues and he delivers;
he performs signs and wonders
in the heavens and on the earth,
for he has delivered Daniel
from the paw of the lions."
28 So this Daniel prospered in the reign of Darius and in the reign of
Cyrus the Persian.[f]

Notes

- a (6:1) Verses 1–28 are 6:2–29 in the Aramaic text. The number of satrapies under the Persian kings varied; compare Esther 1:1 (127 provinces).
- b (6:6) Or "came by agreement"; the Aramaic verb is used again in verses 11 and 15.
- c (6:10) On praying toward Jerusalem compare 1 Kings 8:35, 44, 48; on three times a day compare Psalm 55:17.
- d (6:18) The meaning of the Aramaic word is uncertain; suggestions include "musicians," "concubines," and "food."
- e (6:24) Aramaic "had eaten the pieces of Daniel"; see the note at 3:8.
- f (6:28) Or "in the reign of Darius, that is, in the reign of Cyrus the Persian." See the note at 5:31.

Chapter 7

1 In the first year of Belshazzar king of Babylon,[a] Daniel saw a dream
and visions of his head as he lay on his bed. He then wrote down
the dream, telling the sum of the matters. 2 Daniel declared: "I was
looking in my vision by night, and there were the four winds of
heaven stirring up the great sea.[b] 3 Four great beasts came up out of
the sea, each different from the others. 4 The first was like a lion, with
an eagle's wings. I watched until its wings were plucked away; it was
raised up from the earth and made to stand on two feet like a human
being, and a human heart was given to it. 5 And there was another
beast, a second one, that looked like a bear. It was raised up on one
side, with three ribs between its teeth in its mouth, and these words

were spoken to it: ‘Get up and eat plenty of meat!’ 6 After this I kept looking, and there was another, like a leopard, with four bird’s wings on its back; the beast had four heads, and dominion was given to it. 7 After this I kept looking in the night visions, and there was a fourth beast, dreadful and terrible and exceedingly strong. It had great teeth of iron; it devoured and crushed, and what was left it trampled with its feet. It was unlike all the beasts before it, and it had ten horns. 8 While I was pondering the horns, another horn, a little one, came up among them, and three of the first horns were plucked up by the roots before it. In this horn were eyes like a man’s eyes and a mouth speaking great things.

9 “I kept watching
until thrones were placed,
and the Ancient of Days[c] sat down.
His garment was as white as snow,
and the hair of his head like clean wool;
his throne was fiery flames,
and its wheels blazing fire.
10 A stream of fire was pouring out
from before him.
Thousands upon thousands waited on him,
and myriads upon myriads stood in front of him.
The court took its seat,
and the books were opened.

11 “Then I kept watching because of the sound of the great words the horn was speaking. I watched until the beast was killed, and its body destroyed and given over to be burned with fire. 12 As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was taken away, but their lives were prolonged for a season and a time.

13 “In the night visions I kept watching,
and look, coming with the clouds of heaven
was someone like a son of man.[d]
He approached the Ancient of Days
and was led into his presence.

14 He was given authority,
glory and a kingdom,
so that every people, nation and language
would serve him.
His authority is eternal authority
that will not fade,
and his kingdom is one
that will never be destroyed.

15 "I, Daniel, was troubled in my spirit within me,[e] and the visions in
my mind frightened me. 16 I went up to one of the attendants standing
there and inquired of him the truth of all this. He spoke to me and
let me know what these things meant: 17 'These four great beasts
are four kings who will arise from the earth. 18 But the holy ones of
the Most High[f] will receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom
forever, forever and ever.'

19 "Then I wanted to learn the truth about the fourth beast, which
differed from all the rest and was terrifying, with iron teeth and
bronze claws, and which ate and crushed and stamped on whatever
remained with its feet, 20 and about the ten horns on its head, and the
other horn that grew up and made three fall—the horn that had eyes
and a mouth that spoke boastfully, and that looked bigger than the
rest. 21 As I looked, this horn was waging war against the holy ones
and prevailing over them, 22 until the Ancient of Days arrived, and a
verdict was given in favor of the holy ones of the Most High, and the
moment came when the holy ones took over the kingdom.

23 "He spoke thus:
'As for the fourth beast, there will be a fourth kingdom on earth,
unlike every other kingdom;
it will devour the whole earth,
tread it down and break it in pieces.
24 The ten horns:
from this kingdom ten kings will rise,
and after them yet another will rise.
He will differ from those before him,
and three kings he will humble.

25 He will say hostile words against the Most High
and wear out the holy ones who belong to the Most High;
he will intend to change the seasons and the law,
and for a time, times and half a time
the holy ones will be under his control.[g]
26 Then the court will sit,
and his dominion will be removed,
to be consumed and brought to ruin forever.
27 Then the kingdom, the authority
and the greatness of all the kingdoms under heaven
will be given to the people who are the holy ones of the Most High.
Their kingdom is an eternal kingdom,
and every ruler will serve and obey them.'[h]
28 "Here the account ends. As for me, Daniel, my thoughts troubled me greatly and my face grew pale, but I kept the matter to myself."[i]

Notes

- a (7:1) About 553 BC, if Belshazzar's regency is counted from Nabonidus's departure for Teima. Chapters 7–12 are visions told in the first person, arranged by date; chapter 7 is earlier than chapters 5–6.
- b (7:2) In the Bible the sea often stands for the forces of chaos opposed to God (compare Isaiah 27:1; Job 26:12; Revelation 13:1).
- c (7:9) Aramaic ʿattiq yomin, "one advanced in days," that is, an aged one, a picture of God as eternal judge.
- d (7:13) Aramaic kebar ʾenash, "one like a human being." In contrast to the beasts from the sea, a humanlike figure comes with the clouds of heaven, which elsewhere in the Bible accompany God himself. In verses 18, 22, and 27 the kingdom is given to "the holy ones of the Most High," and many interpreters take the figure as representing them; others identify him as a heavenly being, perhaps the angel Michael (compare 10:13, 21; 12:1). Later Jewish texts (1 Enoch, 4 Ezra) and the Gospels understand him as an individual, messianic figure, and Jesus uses "the Son of Man" of himself with direct reference to this verse (Mark 13:26; 14:62).
- e (7:15) Aramaic "in the midst of its sheath," that is, within my body.
- f (7:18) The holy ones are probably God's faithful people (compare verse 27, "the people of the holy ones of the Most High"), though some take them as angels. The Aramaic word for "Most High" here and in verses 22, 25, and 27 is plural in form (ʿelyonin), a plural of majesty.
- g (7:25) That is, probably three and a half years (compare 9:27; 12:7; Revelation 12:14). Many interpreters see a reference to the persecution of the Jews by Anti-

ochus IV Epiphanes, who in 167 BC banned the observance of the Sabbath and festivals and the keeping of the law (1 Maccabees 1:41–64).

- h (7:27) Or "Their kingdom … serve and obey them," referring to the people. The Aramaic pronoun is singular and can refer either to the people or to the Most High.
- i (7:28) This is the end of the Aramaic section that began at 2:4b. From 8:1 the book is again written in Hebrew.

Chapter 8

1 In the third year of King Belshazzar's reign, I, Daniel,[a] saw a vision,
following the one I had seen earlier. 2 I looked in the vision, and as
I looked I was at Susa the citadel, in the province of Elam; and in
the vision I was by the Ulai Canal.[b] 3 Lifting up my eyes, I saw a
ram standing before the canal. It had two horns, both of them high,
but one higher than the other, and the higher one came up last. 4 I
watched the ram charging westward, northward, and southward. No
beast could stand against it, nor could anyone deliver from its hand.
It did whatever it wished and grew great.
5 While I was thinking about this, a male goat came from the west,
covering the whole earth without its feet touching the ground.
Between its eyes the goat had a prominent horn. 6 It approached the
ram with two horns that I had seen standing beside the canal, and
charged at it with all its furious power. 7 I saw it reach the ram; it
was enraged against it, struck the ram, and broke its two horns, and
the ram had no strength to stand before it. It threw the ram down to
the ground and trampled on it, and there was no one to rescue the
ram from its power. 8 The male goat became enormously powerful.
But when it was at its strongest, the large horn snapped off, and four
prominent horns grew in its place, pointing toward the four winds of
the sky.
9 Out of one of them came forth a single horn, a small one,[c] which
grew exceedingly great toward the south, toward the east, and toward
the Beautiful Land. 10 It grew great, even to heaven's host, and cast
down to earth some of the host and some of the stars, and trampled
them. 11 It even made itself as great as the Prince of the host; from
him the regular burnt offering[d] was taken away, and the place of his
sanctuary was overthrown. 12 Because of transgression a host was

given over to it together with the regular burnt offering,[e] and it cast truth to the ground; it acted and prospered. 13 Then I heard a certain holy one speak, and another holy one asked the one speaking, "How long is the vision about the regular burnt offering, and the desolating transgression,[f] and the trampling of sanctuary and host that has been permitted?" 14 He said to me,[g] "For two thousand three hundred evenings and mornings; then the sanctuary will be restored to its right state."

15 When I, Daniel, had seen the vision, I sought to understand it; and there before me stood one who looked like a man. 16 And I heard a human voice between the banks of the Ulai, which called out, "Gabriel,[h] make this man understand the vision." 17 He came beside the place where I was standing, and at his coming I was terrified and fell on my face. He said to me, "Understand, son of man,[i] that the vision belongs to the time of the end." 18 While he was speaking with me, I fell into a deep sleep with my face to the ground; but he touched me and set me on my feet. 19 He said, "I am going to make known to you what will happen in the latter part of the wrath, for it concerns the appointed time of the end. 20 The two-horned ram that you saw stands for the kings of Media and Persia. 21 The hairy goat is the king of Greece,[j] and the large horn between its eyes is the first king. 22 As for the horn that was broken, in whose place four arose, four kingdoms will arise from his nation, but not with his power. 23 Near the end of their rule, when the rebels have done their worst, a king will appear, hard-faced[k] and skilled in trickery. 24 His power will be mighty, but not by his own power.[l] He will cause astounding destruction and will succeed in what he does. He will destroy mighty men and the people of the holy ones. 25 Through his cleverness he will make deception succeed under his control, and in his mind he will think himself great. He will destroy many people who feel secure, and he will even challenge the Prince of princes; yet he will be shattered, though not by human power. 26 The vision of the evenings and the mornings that was told is true. But you are to seal up the vision, for it concerns days far off."

27 I, Daniel, was exhausted and was ill for several days. Afterward I
got up and attended to the king's affairs; yet I was dismayed at the
vision, and no one could make it plain.[m]

Notes

- a (8:1) From here to the end of the book the text is in Hebrew. The Qumran manuscripts 4QDan-a and 4QDan-b, as reported, preserve this change from Aramaic back to Hebrew.
- b (8:2) Or "the Ulai Gate." Susa was the Persian royal winter capital (compare Nehemiah 1:1; Esther 1:2). The Ulai was a watercourse near the city.
- c (8:9) The little horn is generally identified as Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–164 BC), of the Seleucid dynasty, one of the four kingdoms into which Alexander's empire was divided. "The Beautiful Land" is Israel (compare 11:16, 41; Jeremiah 3:19).
- d (8:11) Hebrew hattamid, "the continual (offering)," the burnt offering presented every morning and evening (Exodus 29:38–42); likewise in verses 12–13 and at 11:31; 12:11. Antiochus stopped the temple sacrifices in December 167 BC (1 Maccabees 1:45, 54).
- e (8:12) The Hebrew of this verse is very difficult, and the translation is uncertain.
- f (8:13) Hebrew happesha' shomem. Compare "the abomination that makes desolate" at 9:27; 11:31; 12:11, and the note at 9:27.
- g (8:14) Most Hebrew manuscripts read "to me"; the Old Greek, Theodotion, and the Syriac read "to him." The 2,300 evenings and mornings may mean 2,300 days or, counting the evening and morning sacrifices separately, 1,150 days, roughly the period from the stopping of the sacrifices to the rededication of the temple in December 164 BC.
- h (8:16) The name means "God is my mighty one" or "man of God." Gabriel and Michael (10:13) are the only angels named in the Old Testament.
- i (8:17) Hebrew ben-'adam, "human being," as in Ezekiel.
- j (8:21) Hebrew Yavan (Ionia), the usual Hebrew name for the Greeks. The first king is Alexander the Great (336–323 BC).
- k (8:23) Hebrew "strong of face," that is, insolent, shameless. "Skilled in intrigue" is literally "understanding riddles."
- l (8:24) The phrase "but not by his own power" may have been copied by mistake from verse 22.
- m (8:27) Or "and did not understand it."

Chapter 9

1 In the first year of Darius son of Ahasuerus,[a] a Mede by descent, who
was made king over the realm of the Chaldeans— 2 in the first year of
his reign, I, Daniel, understood from the books the number of years

that the word of Yahweh to the prophet Jeremiah said would have to pass before the desolation of Jerusalem ended: seventy years.[b]
3 Then I set my face toward the Lord God to seek him with prayer and supplications, fasting in sackcloth and ashes. 4 I prayed to Yahweh my God and confessed: "Lord, great and awe-inspiring God, you who keep your covenant and faithful love toward those who love you and obey your commands: 5 We have sinned; we have committed iniquity and done wickedly; we have rebelled and departed from your commands and your rulings. 6 We have not listened to your servants the prophets, who spoke in your name to our kings, our princes, and our fathers, and to all the people of the land. 7 You, Lord, are in the right, but we are covered with shame,[c] as we are today—the people of Judah, the residents of Jerusalem, and all Israel, both nearby and far away, in every country where you scattered them because of their unfaithfulness to you. 8 Yahweh, open shame belongs to us, to our kings, our princes, and our fathers, because we have sinned against you. 9 To the Lord our God belong compassion and forgiveness, for we rebelled against him 10 and did not obey the voice of Yahweh our God by following the laws he gave us through his servants the prophets. 11 All Israel has transgressed your law and turned aside, refusing to listen to your voice. So the curse and the oath written in the law of Moses the servant of God have been poured out on us,[d] because we have sinned against him. 12 He has carried out his words that he spoke against us and against our rulers who ruled us,[e] by bringing on us a great calamity; for under the whole heaven nothing has been done like what has been done against Jerusalem. 13 Just as it stands written in the law of Moses, all this disaster has come upon us; still we have not sought the favor of Yahweh our God, turning from our iniquities and paying heed to your truth. 14 Therefore Yahweh kept watch over the calamity and brought it upon us, for Yahweh our God is righteous in all the works he has done, and we have not listened to his voice. 15 And now, Lord our God, you brought your people out of Egypt with a strong hand and made yourself famous, as you are today: but we have sinned and done evil. 16 Lord, in line with all your acts of justice, turn your anger and fury away from Jerusalem,

your city and your holy mountain; for because of our sins and the wrongdoing of our ancestors, all our neighbors scorn Jerusalem and your people. 17 So now, our God, listen to your servant's prayer and his requests for mercy, and for the sake of the Lord[f] let your face shine on your devastated sanctuary. 18 Incline your ear, my God, and hear; open your eyes and look upon our desolations and upon the city that bears your name. It is not on the ground of our righteous deeds that we lay our supplications before you, but on the ground of your abundant mercies. 19 Lord, listen! Lord, pardon! Lord, pay attention and act! Do not wait, for your own sake, my God, because your city and your people carry your name."

20 While I was still speaking and praying, confessing my sin and the sin of my people Israel, and presenting my plea before Yahweh my God on behalf of the holy mountain of my God— 21 yes, while I was still speaking in prayer, Gabriel—the man I had seen in the earlier vision —came close to me in swift flight[g] around the hour of the evening offering. 22 He gave me understanding and said to me, "Daniel, I have come out now to give you wisdom and understanding. 23 At the beginning of your pleas a word went out, and I have come to tell it, for you are greatly treasured.[h] So consider the word and understand the vision:

24 "Seventy weeks[i] have been determined for your people and your holy city:

to end rebellion,
to finish with sin,[j]
to make atonement for wrongdoing,
to bring in eternal righteousness,
to seal up vision and prophecy,
and to anoint the most holy place.[k]

25 Know and understand: from the going out of the word to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until an anointed one, a prince,[l] there will be seven weeks; and for sixty-two weeks it will be rebuilt, with plaza and moat, but in a time of distress.

26 After the sixty-two weeks an anointed one will be cut off, with nothing left to him.[m] The people of the coming prince will destroy

the city and the sanctuary. The end will come like a flood, and war will continue until the end; devastations have been determined.
27 He will confirm a covenant with many for one week; in the middle of the week he will stop sacrifice and grain offering. On a wing of abominations will come one who devastates,[n] until the determined end is poured out on the one who devastates."

Notes

- a (9:1) Hebrew ʾAḥashwerosh, the name elsewhere used of Xerxes (Esther 1:1). On Darius the Mede see the note at 5:31.
- b (9:2) See Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10; compare 2 Chronicles 36:21.
- c (9:7) Hebrew "shame of face"; likewise in verse 8.
- d (9:11) See Leviticus 26:14–39; Deuteronomy 28:15–68.
- e (9:12) Hebrew "our judges who judged us."
- f (9:17) Theodotion reads "for your sake, Lord."
- g (9:21) Or "when I was utterly weary"; the Hebrew is uncertain. The evening offering was made in the late afternoon (compare Exodus 29:39–41; Ezra 9:4–5).
- h (9:23) Hebrew ḥamudot, "precious things, a treasure"; likewise at 10:11, 19.
- i (9:24) Hebrew shavuʿim shivʿim, "seventy sevens," that is, seventy periods of seven, generally understood as weeks of years, 490 years in all, an expansion of Jeremiah's seventy years (verse 2; compare Leviticus 25:8; 26:18). The interpretation of verses 24–27 is among the most debated in the Bible. Many modern interpreters take the final week to be the period of the persecution under Antiochus IV (171–164 BC); traditional Christian interpretation has generally related the anointed one and the final week to Christ, and traditional Jewish interpretation to the destruction of the second temple in AD 70. The schemes differ in their starting points and in how literally they take the numbers.
- j (9:24) So the written text (Kethiv), "to seal up sin"; the reading tradition (Qere) has "to bring sin to an end."
- k (9:24) Or "a most holy one." The phrase qodesh qodashim, "holy of holies," is used elsewhere of the sanctuary, its altar, or its holy things, never clearly of a person.
- l (9:25) Or "the Anointed One, the Prince" or "Messiah the Prince" (so the KJV). Hebrew mashiaḥ, "anointed," is used of kings, priests, and once of Cyrus (Isaiah 45:1); there is no article. The Masoretic punctuation separates the "seven weeks" from the "sixty-two weeks," as here; Theodotion and the KJV join them ("seven weeks, and threescore and two weeks"). Candidates for the anointed one of this verse include Zerubbabel, the high priest Joshua, and Cyrus (compare Ezra 1:1–4; 3:2), and, on the other punctuation, Christ.
- m (9:26) Or "and there will be no one for him." Many see here the murder of the high priest Onias III in 171 BC (compare 11:22; 2 Maccabees 4:33–38); traditional Christian interpretation sees the death of Christ.

- n (9:27) Hebrew shiqquṣim meshomem; compare 11:31 (“the abomination that makes desolate”) and 12:11. The phrase is probably a deliberate distortion of a title of the god Baal Shamem, “Lord of heaven,” the Syrian equivalent of Olympian Zeus, to whom Antiochus IV dedicated the Jerusalem temple and set up an altar or image on the altar of burnt offering in December 167 BC (1 Maccabees 1:54, “a desolating sacrilege”; 2 Maccabees 6:2). Jesus speaks of “the abomination of desolation” as a sign of the future (Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14), and many Christian interpreters have referred this verse to the Roman destruction of the temple in AD 70 or to events still to come. “The wing” may mean a wing or pinnacle of the temple.

Chapter 10

1 In the third year of Cyrus king of Persia[a] a word was revealed to
Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar. True was the word, and it
concerned a great conflict.[b] He grasped the word, and understanding
of the vision was given him.
2 In those days I, Daniel, was mourning for three whole weeks. 3 I ate
no delicacies; no meat or wine entered my mouth, and I did not anoint
myself at all until the three weeks were over. 4 On the twenty-fourth
day of the first month (in March–April),[c] as I was on the bank of the
great river, the Tigris,[d] 5 I raised my eyes and looked, and behold,
a man dressed in linen, his waist girded with gold of Uphaz.[e] 6 His
body was like chrysolite,[f] his face had the appearance of lightning, his
eyes were like torches of fire, his arms and feet gleamed like polished
bronze, and his words sounded like the noise of a crowd. 7 I, Daniel,
alone saw the vision; the men who were with me did not see it, but a
great trembling fell on them, and they fled to hide themselves. 8 So I
was left alone and saw this great vision. No strength remained in me;
my vigor was turned to pallor,[g] and I kept no strength. 9 Yet I heard
the sound of his words; and on hearing them I sank into a deep sleep
upon my face, my face toward the ground.
10 Then a hand touched me and set me trembling on my knees and the
palms of my hands. 11 He said to me, “Daniel, you are highly esteemed;
understand the words I am about to tell you, and stand up straight,
because I have now been sent to you.” When he had said this, I rose
to my feet, shaking. 12 He said to me, “Do not fear, Daniel, for from the
first day that you set your heart to understand and to humble yourself
before your God, your words were heard, and I have come because

of your words. 13 The prince of the kingdom of Persia[h] withstood me twenty-one days, but Michael,[i] one of the chief princes, came to help me, and I left him there with the kings of Persia.[j] 14 I have come to make you understand what will happen to your people in the latter days, for there is yet a vision for those days."

15 While he was speaking these words with me, I turned my face toward the ground and was speechless. 16 Then one in the likeness of the sons of men touched my lips, and I opened my mouth and spoke. I said to the one standing before me, "My lord, because of the vision pains have come upon me,[k] and I have kept no strength. 17 How can my lord's servant, such as I am, talk with my lord? As for me, no strength remains in me now, and no breath is left in me."

18 Again one who looked like a man touched me, and he gave me strength. 19 He said, "Do not fear, man greatly treasured. Peace be with you; be strong, be strong!" As he spoke with me I was strengthened, and I said, "Let my lord speak, for you have strengthened me." 20 Then he said, "Do you know why I have come to you? Now I will return to fight against the prince of Persia; and when I go out, behold, the prince of Greece will come. 21 Yet I will declare to you what is written in the book of truth. Not one stands firm beside me against these but Michael, your prince.

Notes

- a (10:1) That is, 536 BC.
- b (10:1) Or "and of great hardship"; Hebrew tsava' gadol, "a great host" or "a hard service."
- c (10:4) Hebrew "the first month," Nisan. The fast of verses 2–3 would have included Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread (the 14th to the 21st of the month).
- d (10:4) Hebrew Ḥiddeqel. The Syriac reads "the Euphrates," which is usually called "the great river" (Genesis 15:18).
- e (10:5) An unknown place; perhaps a corruption of Ophir (compare Jeremiah 10:9).
- f (10:6) Hebrew tarshish, a precious stone of uncertain identity, perhaps yellow jasper or topaz.
- g (10:8) Hebrew "my splendor was changed upon me to ruin."
- h (10:13) A heavenly being who represents and champions Persia, as Michael does Israel (verse 21; 12:1); compare Deuteronomy 32:8 in the Septuagint and Qumran readings ("according to the number of the sons of God").
- i (10:13) The name means "Who is like God?"

- j (10:13) So the Hebrew; the Old Greek and Theodotion read "I left him there with the prince of the kingdom of Persia."
- k (10:16) Hebrew "my pangs are turned upon me," the word used of a woman's labor pains.

Chapter 11

1 "And as for me, in the first year of Darius the Mede, I stood up to
confirm and strengthen him.[a] 2 Now I will declare the truth to you.
Three more kings will arise in Persia, and a fourth will be far richer
than all of them. When he has grown strong through his riches,
he will stir up everyone against the kingdom of Greece.[b] 3 Then a
warrior king will stand up and hold sway over a vast dominion, doing
whatever he wishes.[c] 4 But as soon as he has arisen, his kingdom will
be broken and parceled out toward the four winds of heaven, but not
to his descendants, nor with the dominion that he wielded; for his
kingdom will be uprooted and go to others besides these.
5 "Then the king of the south will grow strong, but one of his com-
manders will grow stronger than he and will rule a dominion greater
than his.[d] 6 Some years later they will make a pact: the daughter of
the king of the south will go to the king of the north to establish an
agreement. But she will not keep her power, and neither he nor his
power will last; she will be handed over, along with her escorts, her
child[e] and the one who backed her in those days. 7 But a branch from
her family line will rise to take his place.[f] He will attack the army and
enter the stronghold of the king of the north, and he will fight them
and win. 8 He will even seize their gods, along with their cast idols
and their valuable articles of silver and gold, and take them off as
plunder to Egypt; and for some years he will stay away from the king
of the north. 9 Then the king of the north will attack the kingdom of
the king of the south, but will return to his own country.
10 "His sons will wage war and gather a multitude of great forces,
which will keep coming on and overflow like a flood and pass
through, and again carry the war as far as his fortress.[g] 11 Then the
king of the south, moved with rage, will go out and fight against
him, the king of the north, who will raise a great multitude; but the
multitude will be given into the hand of his enemy.[h] 12 When the

multitude is carried off, his heart will be exalted; he will bring down
tens of thousands, but he will not prevail. 13 For the king of the north
will raise another army, larger than the first, and after some years[i]
he will march out with a huge force and plenty of equipment. 14 In
those times many will rise up against the king of the south, and the
violent men among your own people will lift themselves up to fulfill
the vision, but they will stumble. 15 Then the king of the north will
come and throw up siege mounds and capture a well-fortified city.
The forces of the south will not stand, nor even his choice troops;
there will be no strength to stand.[j] 16 But he who comes against him
will do as he wills, and no one will stand before him. He will take his
stand in the Beautiful Land, with destruction in his hand. 17 He will
set his face to come with the strength of his whole kingdom, and he will
make an agreement with him and give him a daughter in marriage[k]
to destroy the kingdom;[l] but it will not stand or serve his purpose. 18
After that he will turn his attention to the coastlands and take many
of them. But a commander will stop his insolence; yes, he will repay
him for his insolence.[m] 19 Then he will turn his face back toward the
fortresses of his own land, but he will stumble and fall and be found
no more. 20 Then there will arise in his place one who will send out
an exactor of tribute through the glory of the kingdom;[n] but within
a few days he will be broken, neither in anger nor in battle.
21 "A despicable person[o] will take his place, someone who was never
given the honor of royalty. He will arrive when no one expects it
and take over the kingdom through trickery. 22 Armies will be utterly
swept away before him like a flood and broken, and the prince of the
covenant[p] as well. 23 From the time an alliance is made with him he
will practice deceit; he will go up and become strong with only a few
people. 24 Stealthily he will invade the richest places of the province
and do what none of his fathers or his fathers' fathers ever did,
distributing among them plunder, spoil, and goods. Against fortresses
he will devise his schemes, but only for a time. 25 He will stir up his
power and his heart against the king of the south with a great army.
The king of the south will wage war with an exceedingly great and
mighty army, but he will not stand, for they will devise plans against

him.[q] 26 Those who eat his rich food will break him; his army will be
swept away, and many will fall slain. 27 As for the two kings, their
hearts will be set on evil; at one table they will speak lies. But it will
not succeed, for the end is yet to be at the appointed time. 28 Then he
will go back to his land laden with riches, his heart opposed to the
holy covenant. He will work his will and return to his own land.[r]
29 "At the appointed time he will come back into the south, but this
time it will not be as it was before. 30 Ships from Kittim[s] will oppose
him, and he will lose courage and turn back. He will be furious at
the holy covenant and act against it; he will return and show favor
to those who abandon the holy covenant. 31 His armed forces will rise
up and defile the sanctuary fortress. They will remove the daily burnt
offering and set up the abomination that causes devastation.[t] 32 Those
who act wickedly against the covenant he will corrupt with smooth
words, but the people who know their God will stand firm and take
action. 33 The wise among the people[u] will give understanding to
many, though for some days they will fall by sword and flame, by
captivity and plunder. 34 As they fall, a little help will come to them,[v]
and many will attach themselves to them with flattery. 35 Some of the
wise will fall, so that refining, purifying, and cleansing may be done
among them until the time of the end, for it is still to come at the
appointed time.
36 "The king will do whatever he pleases. He will lift himself up and
make himself greater than any god, and he will say astonishing things
against the God of gods. He will do well until the time of wrath ends,
because what has been decided will take place. 37 He will ignore the
gods of his ancestors and the one women desire,[w] and he will ignore
every other god, because he will make himself greater than all of
them. 38 Instead, he will honor the god of fortresses—a god his fathers
did not know he will honor with gold and silver, with precious stones
and costly things.[x] 39 He will attack the most heavily defended strong-
holds with the aid of a foreign god. He will shower honor on those
who recognize him, put them in authority over many, and distribute
land in return for payment.

40 “At the time of the end the king of the south will clash with him,
and the king of the north will storm against him with chariots and
horsemen and many ships. He will enter countries and overflow and
pass through.[y] 41 He will enter the Beautiful Land, and many[z] will
stumble; but these will be rescued from his hand: Edom, Moab, and
the chief part of the Ammonites. 42 He will stretch out his hand against
countries, and the land of Egypt will not escape. 43 He will gain control
of the treasures of gold and silver and of all the precious things of
Egypt, and the Libyans and Cushites[aa] will follow in his train. 44 But
news from the east and the north will terrify him, and in a great rage
he will set out to destroy and to devote many to destruction. 45 He will
pitch his royal tents between the sea and the beautiful holy mountain.
Yet his end will come, and no one will help him.

Notes

- a (11:1) The Hebrew is abrupt; “him” is probably Michael (10:21). The Old Greek and Theodotion read “in the first year of Cyrus.” Chapter 11 surveys, in the form of prophecy and without naming names, the history of the Persian kings, Alexander the Great, and the wars between the Ptolemies of Egypt (“the king of the south”) and the Seleucids of Syria (“the king of the north”), culminating in Antiochus IV Epiphanes (verses 21–45). The identifications given in these notes are those commonly proposed.
- b (11:2) The fourth king is probably Xerxes I (486–465 BC), who invaded Greece in 480 BC.
- c (11:3) Alexander the Great.
- d (11:5) Ptolemy I of Egypt and his former general Seleucus I, founder of the Seleucid kingdom.
- e (11:6) So the ancient versions; the Hebrew reads “the one who fathered her.” Berenice, daughter of Ptolemy II, married Antiochus II (about 252 BC); she, her son, and her attendants were murdered after his death.
- f (11:7) Ptolemy III, Berenice’s brother, who invaded the Seleucid kingdom in 246 BC.
- g (11:10) The sons of Seleucus II: Seleucus III and Antiochus III “the Great.”
- h (11:11) The battle of Raphia (217 BC), where Ptolemy IV defeated Antiochus III.
- i (11:13) Hebrew “at the end of the times, years.”
- j (11:15) Probably the capture of Sidon by Antiochus III in about 199 BC.
- k (11:17) Hebrew “the daughter of women.” Antiochus III gave his daughter Cleopatra I in marriage to Ptolemy V in 194/193 BC.
- l (11:17) Or “to destroy him”; the Hebrew is literally “to destroy her.”

- m (11:18) The Roman consul Lucius Scipio defeated Antiochus III at Magnesia in 190 BC. The Hebrew of the last clause is difficult.
- n (11:20) Seleucus IV (187–175 BC), whose minister Heliodorus tried to seize the temple treasury (2 Maccabees 3); "the glory of the kingdom" is probably Jerusalem or its temple.
- o (11:21) Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–164 BC), who took the throne in place of the legitimate heir, his nephew Demetrius.
- p (11:22) Probably the high priest Onias III, deposed in 175 BC and murdered in 171 BC (compare 9:26).
- q (11:25) Antiochus IV's first invasion of Egypt (170–169 BC) against Ptolemy VI.
- r (11:28) In 169 BC Antiochus plundered the temple in Jerusalem (1 Maccabees 1:20–24).
- s (11:30) Kittim originally meant Cyprus, then the western lands generally; here the Romans, whose envoy Popillius Laenas forced Antiochus to leave Egypt in 168 BC. The Old Greek reads "Romans."
- t (11:31) Hebrew hashshiqquṣ meshomem. See the note at 9:27, and compare 8:13; 12:11; 1 Maccabees 1:54; Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14.
- u (11:33) Hebrew maskilim, "those who have insight" or "who make others wise"; likewise in verse 35 and at 12:3, 10.
- v (11:34) Often taken as a reference to the Maccabean revolt, which began in 167 BC.
- w (11:37) Probably the god Tammuz-Adonis (compare Ezekiel 8:14).
- x (11:38) Probably Olympian Zeus, whose cult Antiochus promoted, or Jupiter Capitolinus of Rome.
- y (11:40) Verses 40–45 do not correspond to any known events of Antiochus's last years; he died in Persia in 164 BC, not between the sea and Jerusalem (verse 45). Many scholars therefore think that the author's historical survey ends at verse 39 and that what follows is genuine prediction; others apply these verses to a figure of the last days.
- z (11:41) Or, with a slight change of vowels, "tens of thousands."
- aa (11:43) That is, the people of the upper Nile region (ancient Nubia).

Chapter 12

[1] "At that time Michael will arise,
the great prince who stands guard over your people.
There will be a time of distress
such as has not been since there was a nation
until that time.
But at that time your people will be delivered,
everyone who is found written in the book.

2 And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake,
some to everlasting life,
and some to disgrace and everlasting contempt.[a]
3 The wise will be radiant
like the shining of the firmament,[b]
and those who bring many to righteousness
will be as the stars, forever and ever.
4 But you, Daniel, keep the words secret and seal the book until the time of the end. Many will run to and fro, and knowledge will increase."[c]
5 Then I, Daniel, looked, and two more figures were standing there, one on this side of the river and the other on the opposite side. 6 One of them asked the man dressed in linen, who was above the water of the river, "How long will it be before these amazing events end?" 7 I heard the man dressed in linen, who was above the water of the river, raise both his right and left hands to heaven and swear by the one who lives forever that it would be a time, times and half a time;[d] and when the breaking of the holy people's power is complete, all these things will be finished. 8 I heard, but I did not understand. So I said, "My lord, what will be the outcome of these things?" 9 He said, "Go your way, Daniel, for the words are kept secret and sealed until the time of the end. 10 Many will purify themselves, make themselves white, and be refined, but the wicked will act wickedly. None of the wicked will understand, but the wise will understand. 11 From the time the daily burnt offering is stopped and the abomination that causes devastation[e] is set up, there will be 1,290 days. 12 Blessed is the one who waits and reaches 1,335 days. 13 But you, go your way until the end. You will rest, and you will rise to your allotted place at the end of the days."[f]

Notes

- a (12:2) This is the clearest statement in the Old Testament of a resurrection of the dead to judgment (compare Isaiah 26:19). Hebrew dera'on, "contempt, abhorrence," occurs elsewhere only in Isaiah 66:24.
- b (12:3) Hebrew raqia', the "expanse" or "firmament" of Genesis 1:6–8.
- c (12:4) The Old Greek reads "until many go mad and the earth is filled with wrongdoing."

- d (12:7) See the note at 7:25.
- e (12:11) See the notes at 9:27 and 11:31. The figures of 1,290 days here and 1,335 days in verse 12 both slightly exceed three and a half years (compare 7:25; 8:14); they may be successive recalculations of the expected end.
- f (12:13) Here the Hebrew-Aramaic book of Daniel ends. The Greek versions add the stories of Susanna (placed before chapter 1 in Theodotion) and of Bel and the Dragon (after chapter 12); see the note at 3:23 and the source note.

Hosea

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Hosea[a] son of Beeri in the days of
Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah, and in the days
of Jeroboam son of Joash,[b] king of Israel.
2 When Yahweh first spoke through Hosea, he told him, "Go and
marry a promiscuous woman, and have children who share her
unfaithfulness,[c] because the land is guilty of terrible unfaithfulness
in abandoning Yahweh." 3 So he went and took Gomer daughter of
Diblaim, and she conceived and bore him a son. 4 Yahweh said to him,
"Name him Jezreel,[d] because a little while more and I will avenge the
blood of Jezreel upon the house of Jehu, and I will bring the kingdom
of the house of Israel to an end. 5 On that day I will break the bow of
Israel in the Valley of Jezreel."
6 She conceived again and bore a daughter, and he said to him, "Call
her name Lo-ruhamah,[e] for I will no longer show compassion to the
house of Israel, that I should in any way forgive them. 7 But to the
house of Judah I will show compassion, and I will save them by
Yahweh their God; I will not save them by bow or sword or warfare,
by horses or horsemen."
8 When she had weaned Lo-ruhamah, she conceived and bore a son.
9 And he said, "Call his name Lo-ammi,[f] for you are not my people,
and I am not your I AM."[g]
10 Yet the number of the children of Israel[h] shall be like sand by the sea,
which no one can measure or count; and in the very place where they
were told, "You are not my people," they shall be called, "Children of
the living God."[i] 11 The people of Judah and the people of Israel will
be united again; they will name one leader for themselves and go up
out of the land, because Jezreel's day will be a mighty one.

Notes

- a (1:1) The name means “salvation” or “he has saved,” from the same root as Joshua and Isaiah.
- b (1:1) Hebrew Yo’ash, a variant spelling of Jehoash. Jeroboam II reigned about 786–746 BC; Hosea’s ministry began in his last years and continued after the fall of his dynasty (compare 1:4).
- c (1:2) Hebrew zenunim, “promiscuity, fornication,” used throughout Hosea as a figure for Israel’s worship of other gods (especially Baal) and for its political alliances. Whether Gomer was unfaithful before the marriage or only afterward (looking back from its outcome) is debated.
- d (1:4) The name means “God sows.” Jezreel was the town and valley where Jehu wiped out the house of Ahab (2 Kings 9–10). Jehu’s dynasty ended when his great-great-grandson Zechariah, son of Jeroboam II, was assassinated in about 746 BC (2 Kings 15:8–12). In 2:22–23 the name is turned to promise: God will “sow” Israel in the land.
- e (1:6) The name means “not pitied” or “shown no compassion.”
- f (1:9) The name means “not my people.”
- g (1:9) Hebrew lo’-’ehyeh lakem, “I am not ‘I AM’ to you,” echoing the divine name revealed in Exodus 3:14 (“I AM WHO I AM”). Most translations render “I am not your God,” following the sense.
- h (1:10) Verses 10–11 are 2:1–2 in the Hebrew text.
- i (1:10) Quoted in Romans 9:26.

Chapter 2

1 Say to your brothers, “Ammi,”[a] and to your sisters, “Ruhamah.”
2 “Contend with your mother, contend—
for she is no wife of mine,
and I am no husband of hers—
and let her remove her harlotry from her face,
her adulteries from between her breasts,
3 lest I strip her bare
and set her out as on the day of her birth,
make her like the wilderness,
leave her like a land of drought,
and let her die of thirst.
4 Upon her children also I will have no compassion,
because they are children of whoredom.
5 For their mother has been unfaithful;
the one who bore them has behaved shamefully.
She said, ‘I will chase after my lovers,

who supply my food and drink,
my wool and linen, my oil and my wine.'
6 Therefore I am going to hedge up her[b] way with thorns,
and I will build a wall against her,
so that she cannot find her paths.
7 She will pursue her lovers but not overtake them;
she will search for them but not find them.
Then she will say, 'Let me go back to my first husband,
for it was better with me then than it is now.'
8 She never realized that I was the one who gave her
grain, new wine, and oil,
and piled up silver for her,
and the gold they used for Baal.[c]
9 So I will repossess my grain at harvest
and my new wine in its season;
I will rip away my wool and linen,
which were meant to hide her nakedness.
10 Now I will uncover her shame[d] in the sight of her lovers,
and no one will rescue her out of my hand.
11 I will make all her merriment cease,
her feasts, her new moons, and her Sabbaths,
every one of her appointed times.
12 I will devastate her vines and fig trees,
about which she said, 'These are my pay
from my lovers.'
I will turn them into a jungle,
and wild animals will eat them.
13 I will call her to account for the days of the Baals,
when she offered incense to them,
decked herself with her ring and her necklace,
and went after her lovers,
but forgot me," declares Yahweh.
14 "Therefore, look, I am going to allure her
and lead her into the wilderness,
and speak to her heart.

15 From there I will give back her vineyards to her,
and make the Valley of Achor[e] a doorway of hope.
And there she shall respond as in the days of her youth,
as in the day when she came up out of the land of Egypt.
16 "On that day," announces Yahweh,
"you will address me as 'My husband,'
and you will no more say 'My Baal.'[f]
17 For I will remove the names of the Baals from her mouth,
and they will be remembered by name no more.
18 On that day I will make a treaty for them
with the wild animals, the birds of the sky,
and the crawling creatures.
I will shatter bow, sword, and warfare and remove them from the land,
and I will let everyone rest in safety.
19 I will take you as my bride for all time;
I will take you as my bride with righteousness and justice,
with faithful love and mercy.
20 I will betroth you to me in faithfulness,
and you will know Yahweh.
21 "On that day I will answer," declares Yahweh,
"I will answer the heavens,
and they will answer the earth;
22 the earth will answer the grain, the new wine, and the oil,
and they will answer Jezreel.[g]
23 I will sow her for myself in the land;
on Lo-ruhamah I will have mercy,
and to Lo-ammi I will say, 'You are my people';
and he shall say, 'My God.' "[h]

Notes

- a (2:1) That is, "my people" and "pitied." Verses 1–23 are 2:3–25 in the Hebrew text.
- b (2:6) Hebrew "your"; the Septuagint and Syriac read "her."
- c (2:8) Or "that they used for Baal." Baal was the Canaanite storm god, believed to give rain and fertility.
- d (2:10) Hebrew naḇluth, a rare word, perhaps "lewdness" or "genitals."

- e (2:15) The name means “trouble,” recalling the sin of Achan (Joshua 7:24–26).
- f (2:16) Hebrew ʾishi, “my man, my husband,” and baʿli, “my master, my husband,” a word identical with the name of the god Baal.
- g (2:22) Here the name keeps its meaning, “God sows.”
- h (2:23) Quoted in Romans 9:25 and echoed in 1 Peter 2:10.

Chapter 3

1 Yahweh said to me, “Go once more and love a woman, loved by a lover[a] and committing adultery, even as Yahweh loves the children
of Israel, though they look to other gods and love raisin cakes.”[b] 2 So
I bought her for myself for fifteen pieces of silver and about nine
bushels of barley.[c] 3 I said to her, “For many days you will live with me
as mine. You will not be a prostitute or belong to any other man, and
I will be the same toward you.”[d] 4 For many days the children of Israel
shall remain with no king and no prince, with no sacrifice and no
pillar, with no ephod and no household gods.[e] 5 Afterward the people
of Israel will return and seek Yahweh their God and David their king,
and they will come trembling to Yahweh and to his goodness in the
latter days.

Notes

- a (3:1) Or “loved by a husband” or “loves a companion.” Most take the woman to be Gomer; some think she is another woman.
- b (3:1) Probably offerings used in pagan worship (compare Jeremiah 7:18; 44:19).
- c (3:2) Hebrew “a homer of barley and a lethech of barley,” a homer and a half-homer (about 330 liters). The silver was probably fifteen shekels (about 6 ounces or 170 grams). The Septuagint has “a homer of barley and a skin of wine.”
- d (3:3) The Hebrew is terse; it may mean “so will I also be to you” or “and I too will not come to you.”
- e (3:4) Hebrew teraphim. The pillar (matsseḇah) was a standing stone used in worship; the ephod was a priestly garment used to seek oracles.

Chapter 4

1 Hear the word of Yahweh, children of Israel,
for Yahweh has a dispute[a] with those who live in the land:
no truth is there, no steadfast love,
no knowledge of God in the land.

2 Swearing and deceiving, killing and theft and adultery—they burst all bounds,
and blood touches blood.
3 That is why the land mourns,
and all its residents are wasting away,
together with the creatures of the wild and the flying birds;
even the ocean's fish are vanishing.
4 Yet let no one bring a charge,
let no one rebuke;
for with you is my contention, O priest.[b]
5 By day you shall stumble,
and by night the prophet shall stumble beside you,
and I will make your mother perish.
6 My people perish for want of knowledge.
Since you have spurned knowledge,
I spurn you from serving me as priest;
since you forgot your God's instruction,
your sons I too will forget.
7 The more they increased, the more they sinned against me;
I will change their glory into disgrace.[c]
8 On my people's sin they feed,
and to their iniquity they lift up their appetite.
9 And it will be: like people, like priest.
I will punish them for their ways
and repay them for their deeds.
10 They will eat but never be full;
they will be promiscuous but never increase;
because they have deserted Yahweh
to give themselves to
11 to whoredom.
Wine and new wine take away the understanding.[d]
12 My people ask advice of their wooden thing,
and their rod answers them;
for a spirit of harlotry has misled them,
and they have played the harlot out from under their God.

13 On the tops of the mountains they sacrifice,
and on the hills they burn offerings,
under oak, poplar, and terebinth,
because their shade is good.
Therefore your daughters play the whore,
and your daughters-in-law commit adultery.
14 I will not punish your daughters for their harlotry,
or your daughters-in-law for their adulteries;
for the men themselves go off with harlots
and offer sacrifices with the shrine women;[e]
so a people that does not discern is thrown down.
15 Though you, Israel, play the harlot,
do not let Judah incur guilt.
Do not come to Gilgal;
do not go up to Beth-aven;[f]
do not swear, "As Yahweh lives."
16 For like a stubborn heifer,
Israel is stubborn;
can Yahweh now pasture them
like a lamb in a broad meadow?
17 Ephraim is joined to idols;
leave him alone.
18 When their drinking is over,[g] they give themselves to whoring;
her rulers dearly love shame.
19 A wind has bundled them[h] in its wings,
and their sacrifices will bring them shame.

Notes

- a (4:1) Hebrew rib, a legal dispute or lawsuit.
- b (4:4) The Hebrew is difficult; literally "and your people are like those who contend with a priest."
- c (4:7) An ancient scribal tradition (one of the "corrections of the scribes") says the original read "they exchanged my glory for disgrace."
- d (4:11) Hebrew "the heart," the seat of thought.
- e (4:14) Hebrew qedeshot, "consecrated women," probably women attached to a shrine; the exact nature of their role is debated.

- f (4:15) Beth-aven, “house of wickedness,” is a mocking name for Bethel, “house of God” (compare 5:8; 10:5; Amos 5:5).
- g (4:18) Or “Their liquor is gone” or “Their drink has turned sour.” The Hebrew of verse 18 is very uncertain.
- h (4:19) Hebrew “her.”

Chapter 5

1 Hear this, you priests!
Pay heed, house of Israel!
Give ear, house of the king!
For the judgment concerns you;
for you have been a snare at Mizpah,
and a net spread out upon Tabor.
2 Rebels have gone deep into slaughter,[a]
but I am a rebuke to them all.
3 I know Ephraim,[b]
and Israel is not hidden from me;
for now, Ephraim, you have played the harlot;
Israel is defiled.
4 Their actions will not let them
turn back to their God;
a spirit of prostitution lives inside them,
and they do not know Yahweh.
5 Israel’s arrogance testifies against him;
Israel and Ephraim will fall through their guilt;
Judah too will fall with them.
6 With their flocks and their herds they shall go
to seek Yahweh, but they shall not find him;
he has withdrawn from them.
7 Toward Yahweh they have been treacherous,
for they have fathered children of strangers.
Now a new moon will eat them up, them and their portions.[c]
8 Blow the horn in Gibeah,
the trumpet in Ramah!
Raise the cry at Beth-aven:
“Behind you, Benjamin!”[d]

9 Ephraim will become a wasteland
on the day of punishment;
I announce to Israel's tribes
what is certain.
10 The princes of Judah have become
like those who shift the boundary stone;
on them I will pour out my wrath like water.
11 Ephraim is crushed and oppressed, broken by judgment,
for he willingly walked after filth.[e]
12 So I am like a moth to Ephraim,
and like rot to the house of Judah.
13 When Ephraim noticed his illness,
and Judah his injury,
Ephraim turned to Assyria
and appealed to the great king.[f]
But he cannot cure you
or heal your injury.
14 For I will be like a lion to Ephraim,
and like a young lion to the house of Judah.
I, even I, will tear and go away;
I will carry off, and none shall rescue.
15 I will return to my home
until they admit their guilt and look for me;
in their misery they will seek me eagerly.

Notes

- a (5:2) The Hebrew of this line is obscure; some, with a change of letters, read "they have made deep the pit of Shittim."
- b (5:3) Ephraim, the largest tribe of the north, is Hosea's usual name for the northern kingdom of Israel.
- c (5:7) Or "a month shall devour them with their portions." The meaning is uncertain.
- d (5:8) Verses 8–14 probably reflect the Syro-Ephraimite war of about 734–732 BC (2 Kings 16:5–9; Isaiah 7).
- e (5:11) Hebrew tsaw, of uncertain meaning; perhaps "a command" or a mocking word for idols. The Septuagint reads "vanities."
- f (5:13) Hebrew melek yareḇ, traditionally "King Jareb." With a different division of the letters, malki raḇ, it is the Assyrian royal title "the great king." Likewise at 10:6.

Chapter 6

1 “Come, let us go back to Yahweh;
he has ripped us apart, but he will heal us;
he has wounded us, but he will bandage us.
2 After two days he will revive us;
on the third day he will raise us up,[a]
that we may live before him.
3 Let us know, let us press on to know Yahweh;
his going out is as certain as the dawn;
he will come to us like the showers,
like the spring rain that waters the earth.”
4 Ephraim, what am I to do with you?
Judah, what am I to do with you?
Your loyalty is like mist at morning,
like dew that vanishes early.
5 Therefore I have hewn them by the prophets;
I have slain them by the words of my mouth,
and my judgment goes out like light.[b]
6 For I delight in steadfast love[c] and not sacrifice,
in the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings.
7 But they, like Adam,[d] broke the covenant;
there they betrayed me.
8 Gilead is a town of evildoers,
tracked with blood.
9 As robbers lie in wait for a man,
so a band of priests murders on the road to Shechem;
indeed they commit villainy.
10 In the house of Israel I have seen a horrible thing;
Ephraim’s harlotry is there; Israel is defiled.
11 For you also, Judah, a harvest is appointed,
when I restore the fortunes of my people.

Notes

- a (6:2) A poetic way of saying “very soon.” Early Christian writers saw here a foreshadowing of the resurrection of Christ on the third day (compare 1 Corinthians 15:4).

- b (6:5) So the Septuagint and Syriac, by a different division of the letters; the Hebrew reads “and your judgments are light that goes out.”
- c (6:6) Hebrew ḥeseḏ, loyal, covenant love. The Septuagint has “mercy”; Jesus quotes this verse in Matthew 9:13 and 12:7.
- d (6:7) Or “like mortals” or (with a change of one letter) “at Adam,” a town in the Jordan valley (Joshua 3:16), which would suit “there.”

Chapter 7

1 When I would bring healing to Israel,
then Ephraim’s guilt comes to light,
and Samaria’s wicked acts;
for they deal in falsehood;
thieves break in,
and raiders plunder in the streets.
2 Yet it never occurs to them
that I keep in mind all their evil.
Their own deeds now hem them in;
they stand right in front of me.
3 By their evil they cheer the king,
and by their lies, the officials.
4 They are all adulterers;
they are like an oven heated by the baker,
who ceases to stir the fire
from the kneading of the dough until it is leavened.
5 On the day of our king the princes made themselves sick with the heat of wine;
he stretched out his hand with scoffers.
6 For they draw near; their heart is like an oven in their ambush;
all night their anger[a] sleeps;
in the morning it blazes like a flaming fire.
7 Every one of them is hot like an oven;
they consume those who judge them.[b]
Their kings fall, one after another,
and not one among them calls to me.
8 Ephraim mixes himself among the peoples;
Ephraim is a flat cake not turned.

9 Strangers devour his strength,
and he does not know it;
gray hairs are sprinkled upon him,
and he does not know it.
10 The pride of Israel testifies to his face;
yet they do not return to Yahweh their God,
nor seek him for all this.
11 Ephraim has become like a dove,
gullible and senseless;
to Egypt they call, to Assyria they go.
12 Wherever they go I will cast my net upon them;
like birds of the sky I will pull them down;
I will chasten them as their congregation has heard.[c]
13 Woe to them, for they have wandered away from me!
Ruin upon them, for they have revolted against me!
I would ransom them,
yet they tell lies about me.
14 They do not call to me with their heart
when they howl on their beds;
for the sake of grain and wine they slash themselves;[d]
they turn their backs on me.
15 Though I trained and strengthened their arms,
yet against me they devise evil.
16 They turn, but not toward heaven;[e]
they are like a warped bow.
Their officials will die by the sword
for their insolent speech.
This will make them a laughingstock in Egypt.

Notes

- a (7:6) So the Syriac and Targum; the Hebrew reads "their baker."
- b (7:7) Hebrew "their judges." In the last years of the northern kingdom four of its six kings were assassinated (2 Kings 15).
- c (7:12) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- d (7:14) So some Hebrew manuscripts and the Septuagint; most manuscripts read "they gather themselves together." Gashing the body was a rite of Baal worship (1 Kings 18:28).

- e (7:16) Hebrew lo' 'al, "not up," obscure; perhaps "not to the Most High" or "to what does not profit."

Chapter 8

1 Set the horn to your mouth!
  Like a vulture[a] one comes upon Yahweh's house,
  since they have broken my covenant
  and defied my instruction.
2 To me they cry,
  "My God, we—Israel—know you."
3 Israel has spurned what is good;
  the enemy shall pursue him.
4 They have crowned kings, but not by my will;
  they have appointed princes, but without my knowledge.
  Of their silver and gold they have fashioned idols
  to their own cutting off.
5 Your calf is rejected, Samaria;[b]
  my anger burns against them.
  How long will they be incapable of innocence?
6 For this thing too is out of Israel;
  a workman fashioned it,
  and it is not God.
  Samaria's calf
  will be smashed to pieces.
7 For they sow the wind,
  and they shall reap the whirlwind.
  The standing grain has no head;
  it shall yield no flour;
  and if it should yield,
  strangers would devour it.
8 Israel is swallowed up;
  already they are among the nations
  like a vessel no one wants.

9 For they have gone to Assyria,
like a wild donkey off by itself;
Ephraim has paid for lovers.
10 Though they hire them among the nations,
now I will gather them up.
And they shall soon writhe
under the burden of the king of princes.[c]
11 Ephraim made many altars to take away sin,
but they became altars for committing sin.
12 Though I write for him my laws by the ten thousand,
they are regarded as a strange thing.
13 As for my sacrificial gifts,
they sacrifice meat and eat it;
Yahweh does not accept them.
Now he will remember their iniquity
and punish their sins;
they shall return to Egypt.
14 For Israel has forgotten his Maker
and built palaces,
and Judah has multiplied fortified cities;
but I will send a fire upon his cities,
and it shall devour her strongholds.

Notes

- a (8:1) Or "eagle." "The house of Yahweh" here may mean the land or people of Israel.
- b (8:5) The golden calf set up by Jeroboam I at Bethel (1 Kings 12:28–30). The Hebrew may also be read as a command: "Reject your calf, Samaria."
- c (8:10) Probably the Assyrian king. The Septuagint reads "they shall cease for a little while from anointing a king and princes."

Chapter 9

1 Do not celebrate, Israel,
do not rejoice as other peoples do;
you have been faithless to your God.
You have loved a prostitute's fee
on every threshing floor where grain is beaten.

2 Threshing floor and winepress shall not feed them,
and the new wine shall fail her.
3 They will not stay on Yahweh's land;
Ephraim will go back to Egypt,
and eat what is unclean in Assyria.
4 They will pour out no wine for Yahweh,
and their sacrifices will not please him.
Their meals will resemble funeral food;
anyone who eats it will be defiled;
their bread will only satisfy their hunger;
it will not enter Yahweh's house.
5 What will you do on the solemn day,
the day of Yahweh's festival?
6 For look, they have gone, fleeing from ruin;
Egypt will gather them up,
Memphis[a] will bury them.
Their treasures of silver will be overrun by nettles;
brambles will grow in their tents.
7 The days of reckoning have come,
the days of payment are here;
let Israel know it!
"The prophet is a fool,
the man of the spirit is out of his mind!"—
so great is your iniquity,
so great your hostility.
8 Ephraim is a watchman with my God—the prophet;
yet a bird-catcher's trap lies on all his paths,
and enmity in the house of his God.
9 They have deeply corrupted themselves
as in the days of Gibeah;[b]
he will remember their iniquity;
he will punish their sins.
10 I found Israel
like grapes in the desert;
like the early fruit on a fig tree

at its first bearing
I looked on your ancestors.
But they went to Baal-peor[c]
and dedicated themselves to the Shameful Thing,
and they became as loathsome as the thing they loved.
11 Like a bird Ephraim's glory will fly off—
no childbirth, no womb, no conceiving!
12 Though they raise sons,
I will rob them of them until not one remains.
Woe to them indeed
when I turn away from them!
13 Ephraim, as I have seen, was like Tyre,[d] planted in a meadow;
but Ephraim must lead out his children to slaughter.
14 Give them, Yahweh—
what will you give?
Give them a miscarrying womb
and dry breasts.
15 All their evil is at Gilgal;[e]
there I came to hate them.
Because of the wickedness of their deeds
I will drive them out of my house.
I will love them no more;
all their princes are rebels.
16 Ephraim is stricken;
their root is dried up;
they shall bear no fruit.
Even though they give birth,
I will put to death their cherished offspring.
17 My God will cast them off,
for they have not obeyed him,
and among the nations they will be wanderers.

Notes

- a (9:6) Hebrew Moph, the ancient capital of Lower Egypt, near modern Cairo, famous for its necropolis.
- b (9:9) See Judges 19–21.

- c (9:10) See Numbers 25:1–5. “The Shameful Thing” (Hebrew bosheth) is a common substitute for the name Baal.
- d (9:13) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- e (9:15) Gilgal was a major sanctuary (4:15; 12:11; Amos 4:4) and the place where Saul was made king (1 Samuel 11:15).

Chapter 10

1 Israel is a rambling vine[a]
that puts forth fruit for itself.
As his fruit grew plentiful,
so he added altars;
as his land grew good,
so he made his pillars handsome.
2 Their heart is false;[b]
now they must bear their guilt.
He himself will break down their altars
and wreck their pillars.
3 For soon they will say,
“We have no king,
because we did not fear Yahweh;
and a king—what could he do for us?”
4 They speak mere words;
with empty oaths they cut covenants;
so judgment springs up like poisonous weeds
in the furrows of the field.
5 For the calf[c] of Beth-aven
the people of Samaria tremble.
Its people mourn over it,
and its idol-priests[d] writhe over it,
over its glory, because it has departed from them into exile.
6 The thing itself will be carried to Assyria
as tribute to the great king.[e]
Ephraim will be put to shame,
and Israel will be disgraced for his counsel.
7 Samaria and her king are swept off[f]
like a chip on the face of the waters.

8 The high places of Aven,[g] the sin of Israel,
will be wiped out.
Thorn and thistle will climb over their altars,
and they will say to the mountains, “Cover us,”
and to the hills, “Fall on us.”[h]
9 Since the days of Gibeah you have sinned, Israel;
there they have stood fast.[i]
Will not war overtake them in Gibeah,
against the children of injustice?
10 When I please, I will chasten them,
and peoples will be gathered against them
when they are bound for their double iniquity.[j]
11 Ephraim was a heifer well taught,
fond of threshing,
and I passed over her fair neck;[k]
but now I will harness Ephraim;
Judah shall drag the plow;
Jacob shall break the clods for himself.
12 Plant righteousness for yourselves;
harvest the fruit of faithful love;
plow your fallow ground,
for it is time to seek Yahweh,
until he comes
and showers righteousness on you.[l]
13 You have plowed wickedness;
you have reaped injustice;
you have eaten falsehood’s fruit.
Since you relied on your own way,[m]
on your multitude of warriors,
14 the din of war shall rise against your people,
and every fortress of yours shall be ruined,
as Shalman[n] ruined Beth-arbel in the day of battle,
when the mother was dashed to pieces upon her children.
15 So it shall be done to you, Bethel,
because of your utter wickedness.

At daybreak the king of Israel
will be cut off completely.

Notes

- a (10:1) Or "a luxuriant vine"; the Hebrew boqeq can also mean "empty" or "ravaged."
- b (10:2) Or "divided" or "slippery."
- c (10:5) So the Septuagint; the Hebrew has the feminine plural, "calves," perhaps in mockery.
- d (10:5) Hebrew kemarim, a word used only of priests of false gods (2 Kings 23:5; Zephaniah 1:4).
- e (10:6) See the note at 5:13.
- f (10:7) Or "Samaria's king is destroyed."
- g (10:8) That is, Beth-aven (Bethel); aven means "wickedness."
- h (10:8) Quoted in Luke 23:30 and echoed in Revelation 6:16.
- i (10:9) The Hebrew of this line is obscure.
- j (10:10) So a Hebrew reading (Qere); the written text (Kethiv) may mean "their two springs" or "their two eyes."
- k (10:11) Hebrew "I passed over the goodness of her neck." Threshing was light work, and the ox was free to eat while it worked (Deuteronomy 25:4).
- l (10:12) Or "teaches you righteousness"; the Hebrew verb yarah can mean both "to rain" and "to teach." The Septuagint reads "until the fruits of righteousness come to you."
- m (10:13) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint reads "in your chariots."
- n (10:14) Perhaps Shalmaneser V of Assyria (727–722 BC) or Salamanu, a king of Moab mentioned in Assyrian records. Neither the event nor the location of Beth-arbel is otherwise known.

Chapter 11

1 When Israel was a youth, I loved him,
and from Egypt I summoned my son.[a]
2 The more they[b] called them,
the farther they went from them;[c]
they kept sacrificing to the Baals
and burning offerings to carved images.
3 But I myself taught Ephraim to walk,
lifting them in my[d] arms;
yet they never knew that it was I who healed them.
4 I drew them with human ties,
with bonds of love;

I was like someone who lifts the yoke from their necks,[e]
and I stooped down and fed them.
5 They will not[f] go back to Egypt;
Assyria will rule them,
because they refuse to come back to me.
6 The sword will whirl through their cities;
it will make an end of their gate bars[g]
and devour them because of their schemes.
7 My people are bent on turning from me;
though they call to the Most High,[h]
he will by no means raise them up.
8 How can I give you up, Ephraim?
How can I hand you over, Israel?
How can I make you like Admah?
How can I treat you like Zeboiim?[i]
My heart turns over within me;
all my compassion grows warm and tender.
9 I will not act on my burning anger;
I will not turn back to destroy Ephraim;
for I am God and not a man,
the Holy One in your midst,
and I will not come in wrath.[j]
10 They will walk after Yahweh;
he will roar like a lion;
when he roars,
his children will come trembling from the west.
11 Like birds they will come trembling out of Egypt,
and like doves from the land of Assyria;
and I will settle them in their homes, declares Yahweh.
12 Ephraim has surrounded me with lies,[k]
and the house of Israel with deceit;
but Judah still wanders with God,[l]
and is faithful to the Holy One.[m]

Notes

- a (11:1) Israel as God's son recalls Exodus 4:22–23. The Septuagint reads "I called his children." Matthew 2:15 quotes the line, following the Hebrew, of the return of the child Jesus from Egypt, seeing in Jesus the one who sums up and fulfills Israel's history.
- b (11:2) The Septuagint reads "I."
- c (11:2) The Septuagint reads "from me."
- d (11:3) So the Septuagint, Syriac, and Vulgate; the Hebrew reads "his."
- e (11:4) Or, with different vowels, "as those who lift an infant to their cheeks."
- f (11:5) Or, joining the word to verse 4, "to him. They will return…"
- g (11:6) Or "their boasters" or "their oracle-priests"; Hebrew baddim.
- h (11:7) Or "they are called to the yoke"; the Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- i (11:8) Two cities destroyed together with Sodom and Gomorrah (Deuteronomy 29:23).
- j (11:9) Or "I will not come into the city."
- k (11:12) Verse 12 is 12:1 in the Hebrew text.
- l (11:12) Or "roams unruly against God." The Hebrew verb is uncertain.
- m (11:12) Or "holy ones."

Chapter 12

1 Ephraim feeds on wind,[a]
and chases the scorching east wind all day;
he piles up lies and violence;
they sign a treaty with Assyria,
and olive oil is shipped to Egypt.
2 Yahweh has a dispute with Judah too;
he will punish Jacob for his conduct
and pay him back for what he has done.
3 In the womb he grabbed his brother's heel,[b]
and in his manhood he strove with God.
4 He strove with the angel and prevailed;
he wept and sought his favor.
At Bethel he found him,[c]
and there he spoke with us[d]—
5 Yahweh, the God of Armies,[e]
Yahweh is his name![f]
6 As for you, return to your God;
keep steadfast love and justice,
and wait on your God continually.

7 A trader, with false scales in his hand,
he loves to defraud.[g]
8 Ephraim boasts, "I have become rich;
I have acquired wealth for myself;
nothing they find in all my work
will count as sin against me."
9 I am Yahweh your God
since the land of Egypt;
once more I will make you dwell in tents,
as in the days of the festival.[h]
10 I spoke through the prophets;
I gave vision upon vision,
and through the prophets I spoke in likenesses.
11 If Gilead is wickedness,
they are surely worthless;
in Gilgal they sacrifice bulls;
their altars also will be like stone heaps
on the furrows of the field.[i]
12 Jacob fled to the open country of Aram;[j]
there Israel served for a wife,
and for a wife he kept sheep.
13 By a prophet Yahweh brought Israel up from Egypt,
and by a prophet he was kept.[k]
14 Ephraim has given bitter provocation;
therefore his Lord will let his blood remain upon him
and pay him back for his contempt.

Notes

- a (12:1) Verses 1–14 are 12:2–15 in the Hebrew text.
- b (12:3) The name Jacob sounds like the Hebrew word for "heel" (Genesis 25:26). For the struggle with God, see Genesis 32:22–32; the name Israel was explained as "he strives with God."
- c (12:4) Or "He found him at Bethel" (Genesis 28:10–22; 35:1–15).
- d (12:4) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Syriac read "with him."
- e (12:5) Hebrew YHWH ʾelohe hatstseḇaʾoth, traditionally "the LORD God of hosts," the God who commands the armies of heaven and of Israel.

- f (12:5) Hebrew zikro, “his memorial,” the name by which he is to be remembered (Exodus 3:15).
- g (12:7) Hebrew kenaʿan, “Canaan,” which also means “merchant.”
- h (12:9) Probably the Feast of Booths, when Israel lived in temporary shelters (Leviticus 23:42–43).
- i (12:11) There are wordplays in Hebrew between Gilead, Gilgal, and gallim, “heaps.”
- j (12:12) See Genesis 28:5; 29:1–30.
- k (12:13) That is, Moses (Deuteronomy 18:15; 34:10).

Chapter 13

1 Once when Ephraim spoke, men trembled;
he was lifted high in Israel;
but he became guilty through Baal, and he died.
2 Now they sin more and more;
they make themselves cast images,
idols from their silver according to their skill,
every one a craftsman’s product.
Of these they say,
“Men who sacrifice kiss calves!”[a]
3 Therefore they will be like the morning mist,
like dew that soon passes away,
like chaff swirled from the threshing floor,
like smoke from a window.[b]
4 But I am Yahweh your God
from the land of Egypt;
you know no God but me,
and besides me there is no savior.[c]
5 It was I who knew you[d] in the wilderness,
in the land of burning drought.
6 As they grazed, they were sated;
sated, their hearts grew proud;
and so they forgot me.
7 So to them I am become a lion;
I will watch by the way like a leopard.

8 Like a bear bereft of her young I will meet them
and rip apart the covering of their heart;[e]
there like a lioness I will consume them;
the beast of the field shall tear them.
9 It is your destruction, Israel,
that you are against me, against your help.[f]
10 Where is your king now, to rescue you in every town?
Where are your rulers,[g]
the ones you asked for:
"Give me a king and officials"?
11 I keep giving you a king in my anger
and taking him away in my fury.
12 The iniquity of Ephraim is tied up in a bundle;
his sin is stored away.
13 Labor pains are coming upon him,
yet he is a son without wisdom,
for at the right time he does not come forth
to the place where children are born.
14 Shall I ransom them from the power of Sheol?[h]
Shall I redeem them from Death?
O Death, where are your plagues?
O Sheol, where is your sting?[i]
Compassion is hidden from my eyes.
15 Though he flourishes among his brothers,[j]
an east wind will come,
the wind of Yahweh rising from the desert,
and his spring will dry up,
his fountain run dry;
it will plunder his treasury
of every precious thing.
16 Samaria will bear her guilt,[k]
because she has rebelled against her God;
they will fall by the sword;
their little ones will be dashed in pieces,
and their pregnant women ripped open.

Notes

- a (13:2) Or "They say to them, 'Sacrifice!' Men kiss calves." The Hebrew is uncertain; kissing an idol was an act of homage (1 Kings 19:18).
- b (13:3) That is, from an opening in the roof or wall through which smoke escaped.
- c (13:4) The Septuagint here adds a long passage on God as creator of heaven and earth.
- d (13:5) The Septuagint and Syriac read "who fed you," a difference of one letter.
- e (13:8) Hebrew "the enclosure of their heart."
- f (13:9) The Hebrew is uncertain. The Septuagint and Syriac read "I will destroy you, Israel; who will help you?"
- g (13:10) Hebrew "your judges." For the request, see 1 Samuel 8:5–6.
- h (13:14) The realm of the dead. The first two lines may also be read as statements: "I will ransom them … I will redeem them."
- i (13:14) Paul quotes these lines, following the Septuagint, in 1 Corinthians 15:55: "O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?"
- j (13:15) There is a wordplay between yaphri', "flourishes," and the name Ephraim.
- k (13:16) Verse 16 is 14:1 in the Hebrew text. Samaria fell to the Assyrians in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:5–6).

Chapter 14

1 Return, Israel, to Yahweh your God,[a]
for your iniquity has made you stumble.
2 Bring words with you
as you return to Yahweh.
Say to him:
"Take every iniquity away,
receive us graciously,
and we will offer the fruit of our lips.[b]
3 Assyria will not save us;
we will not ride on horses;
and we will no more say 'Our God'
to the work of our hands.
In you the orphan finds mercy."
4 I will heal their faithlessness;
I will love them freely,
for my anger has turned away from them.

5 I will be like the dew to Israel;
he will blossom like the lily
and strike root like the trees of Lebanon.[c]
6 His shoots will spread;
his splendor will be like the olive,
and his fragrance like Lebanon.
7 Those who live in his shade will return;
they will grow grain[d]
and blossom like the vine;
their renown will be like the wine of Lebanon.
8 Ephraim, what have I to do with idols anymore?[e]
I answer him, I look after him.
I am like an evergreen cypress;
your fruit is found from me.
9 Who is wise? Let him grasp these things.
Who is discerning? Let him know them.
For straight are the ways of Yahweh;
the righteous walk in them,
but in them transgressors stumble.

Notes

- a (14:1) Verses 1–9 are 14:2–10 in the Hebrew text.
- b (14:2) So the Septuagint and Syriac; the Hebrew reads "we will pay bulls, our lips," meaning that praise will take the place of sacrifices (compare Hebrews 13:15).
- c (14:5) Hebrew "like Lebanon"; likewise in verses 6 and 7.
- d (14:7) Or "they will revive like grain."
- e (14:8) Or "Ephraim will say, 'What more have I to do with idols?' "

Joel

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Joel[a] son of Pethuel.
2 Listen to this, you elders;
hear me, everyone in the land!
Has anything like it occurred in your lifetime,
or in your ancestors' time?
3 Recount it to your children,
and let your children recount it to theirs,
and their children to the generation after.
4 What the cutter left, the swarmer has eaten;
what the swarmer left, the hopper has eaten;
and what the hopper left, the stripper has eaten.[b]
5 Wake up, you drunkards, and weep;
wail, all you who drink wine,
over the sweet wine,
for it is snatched from your mouth.
6 For a nation has come up against my land,
mighty and past counting;
its teeth are a lion's teeth,
and it has the fangs of a lioness.
7 It has turned my vine into a waste
and splintered my fig tree;
it has peeled it bare and thrown it down;
its branches are bleached white.
8 Mourn like a young bride[c] in sackcloth
weeping for the husband of her youth.
9 No grain gift or wine offering
reaches the house of Yahweh.

The priests are in mourning,
Yahweh's servants.
10 The fields are ruined;
the ground mourns;
for the grain is destroyed,
the new wine dries up,
the oil fails.
11 Hang your heads, you tillers of the soil;
howl, you who tend the vines,
for wheat and for barley,
since the field's harvest is lost.
12 The vine has withered;
the fig tree droops;
pomegranate, palm, and apple,[d]
every tree of the field is dried up;
and gladness has withered away
from the children of mankind.
13 Gird on sackcloth and beat your breasts, you priests;
howl, you servants of the altar.
Come, lie all night in sackcloth,
you who serve my God!
For grain offering and drink offering
are kept back from your God's house.
14 Declare a fast;
proclaim a sacred gathering.
Assemble the elders
and every resident of the land
at the house of Yahweh your God,
and call to Yahweh for help.
15 Alas for the day!
For the day of Yahweh is near,
and as destruction from the Almighty it comes.[e]
16 Is not the food cut off
before our very eyes,

joy and gladness
from the house of our God?
17 The seeds shrivel beneath the clods;[f]
the storehouses are desolate;
the granaries are torn down,
for the grain has dried up.
18 How the beasts groan!
The herds of cattle wander in confusion
because they have no pasture;
even the flocks of sheep are made to suffer.[g]
19 To you, Yahweh, I call,
for fire has consumed
the pastures of the wilderness,
and flame has scorched
all the trees of the field.
20 Even the wild beasts pant for you,
for the streams of water have dried up,
and fire has consumed
the pastures of the wilderness.

Notes

- a (1:1) The name means "Yahweh is God."
- b (1:4) Four Hebrew words for locusts (gazam, ʾarbeh, yeleq, ḥasil), perhaps different species or stages of growth, perhaps simply poetic synonyms; the renderings here follow their probable root meanings. Compare 2:25.
- c (1:8) Hebrew bethulah, often "virgin," here probably a young bride whose husband has died before or soon after the marriage.
- d (1:12) Hebrew tappuaḥ, perhaps the apricot or quince.
- e (1:15) There is a wordplay in Hebrew: keshod mishshadday, "like destruction (shod) from Shaddai." Compare Isaiah 13:6.
- f (1:17) The Hebrew of this line contains three words found nowhere else, and its meaning is uncertain.
- g (1:18) Or "bear the guilt." The Septuagint reads "have perished."

Chapter 2

1 Blow the horn in Zion;
sound the alarm on my holy mountain!

Let all who live in the land tremble,
for the day of Yahweh is coming; it is near—
2 a day of darkness and deep gloom,
a day of cloud and heavy darkness!
Like the dawn spread upon the mountains
a people comes, vast and strong;
there has never been anything like it from ancient times,
nor will there be again after it
for years, from generation to generation.
3 Ahead of them fire consumes,
behind them flames burn.
Before them the land is a paradise like Eden,
behind them a barren desert;
nothing gets away.
4 They look like horses,[a]
and they gallop like steeds of war.
5 With a noise like chariots
they leap on the mountaintops,
like the crackle of a flame of fire
consuming stubble,
like a mighty people
drawn up for battle.
6 Before them peoples writhe in anguish;
every face grows pale.[b]
7 Like mighty men they run;
like men of war they climb the wall.
They march each in his own line;
they do not break their ranks.
8 None crowds his neighbor;
each goes in his own path.
Through the weapons[c] they burst
and do not break off.
9 Upon the city they spring;
along the wall they run;

into the houses they climb;
in through the windows they come like a thief.
10 The earth quakes before them;
the heavens shake.
Sun and moon grow dark,
and the stars withdraw their shining.
11 Yahweh utters his voice
before his army,
for his host is exceedingly great;
mighty is he who carries out his word.
For the day of Yahweh is great and very fearsome;
who can endure it?
12 "Yet even now," declares Yahweh,
"turn back to me with your whole heart,
with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning."
13 Rend your heart and not your garments,
and turn back to Yahweh your God;
for he is gracious and merciful,
slow to anger and great in steadfast love,
and he repents of the harm.[d]
14 Who knows whether he will turn and relent
and leave a blessing behind him,
a grain offering and a drink offering
for Yahweh your God?
15 Blow the horn in Zion;
set apart a fast;
call a solemn assembly;
16 gather the people.
Make the assembly holy;
bring together the elders;
gather the little ones,
even babies who nurse at the breast.
Let the bridegroom come out of his chamber,
and the bride from her canopy.

17 Between the porch and the altar[e]
let the priests who serve Yahweh weep
and say, “Have pity on your people, Yahweh,
and do not give your inheritance over to reproach,
for the nations to mock.
Why should they say among the peoples,
‘Where is their God?’ ”
18 Then Yahweh was zealous for his land
and had compassion on his people.
19 Yahweh answered and said to his people,
“Look, I am sending you
grain, new wine, and oil,
and you will be filled with them;
and I will no more make you
a reproach among the nations.
20 The northerner I will drive far from you,
banish him into a land dry and desolate,
his front ranks into the eastern sea,
his hindmost into the western sea.[f]
His stink will go up,
his reek will rise,
for he has done great things.
21 Do not be afraid, O land;
be glad and rejoice,
for Yahweh has done great things!
22 Do not fear, wild animals,
for the desert pastures are turning green;
trees are bearing fruit;
fig and vine are producing richly.
23 Be glad, children of Zion,
and rejoice in Yahweh your God,
for he has given you the early rain in righteousness;[g]
he has poured down showers for you,
the early and the latter rain, as before.

24 The threshing floors will be full of grain,
and the vats will overflow with new wine and oil.
25 I will repay you for the years
that the swarmer has eaten,
the hopper, the stripper, and the cutter,[h]
my great army, which I sent among you.
26 You will eat your fill and be satisfied,
and praise the name of Yahweh your God,
who has dealt wondrously with you.
And my people will never again be put to shame.
27 You will realize that I am present in Israel,
that I am Yahweh your God, and no other exists.
My people will never again be disgraced.
28 "And afterward[i]
I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh;
your sons and your daughters will prophesy;
your old men will dream dreams,
and your young men will see visions.
29 Even upon servants, men and women,
I will pour out my Spirit in those days.
30 I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth:
blood and fire and columns of smoke.
31 The sun will be turned to darkness
and the moon to blood,
before the day of Yahweh comes,
the great and fearsome day.
32 Everyone who invokes Yahweh's name
will be rescued.[j]
On Mount Zion and in Jerusalem
some will escape,
just as Yahweh promised,
and among the survivors
will be those Yahweh summons."

Notes

- a (2:4) The head of a locust resembles that of a horse; compare Revelation 9:7–9. Whether chapter 2 describes a second locust plague, an invading army pictured as locusts, or the apocalyptic army of the day of Yahweh is debated.
- b (2:6) Or "gathers a glow"; the Hebrew is uncertain (compare Nahum 2:10).
- c (2:8) Or "through the water channels."
- d (2:13) Compare Exodus 34:6–7; Jonah 4:2.
- e (2:17) That is, in the court of the priests, between the entrance porch of the temple and the altar of burnt offering.
- f (2:20) The eastern sea is the Dead Sea; the western sea is the Mediterranean.
- g (2:23) Or "the teacher of righteousness." The Hebrew hammoreh can mean either "the early rain" or "the teacher"; the second sense was taken up at Qumran, whose leader was called "the Teacher of Righteousness." The early rain falls in October–November; the latter rain in March–April.
- h (2:25) See the note at 1:4.
- i (2:28) Verses 28–32 are 3:1–5 in the Hebrew text. Peter quotes them at Pentecost (Acts 2:17–21), following the Septuagint with some changes ("in the last days," and "my servants … my maidservants" in verse 29). Compare also Numbers 11:29.
- j (2:32) Quoted in Romans 10:13, where Paul applies "the name of the Lord" to Jesus.

Chapter 3

1 "For look, in those days and at that time,
when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem,[a]
2 I will assemble all the nations
and lead them down into the Valley of Jehoshaphat.[b]
There I will go to law with them
for my people and my inheritance Israel,
whom they dispersed among the nations;
and they parceled out my land.
3 They gambled for my people,
gave a boy in exchange for a prostitute,
and sold a girl for wine to drink.
4 "What do you want with me, Tyre and Sidon, and all the districts of Philistia? Are you taking revenge on me? If so, I will quickly and swiftly return your actions upon your own heads. 5 For you took my silver and my gold and carried my rich treasures into your temples.[c] 6 The people of Judah and of Jerusalem you have sold off to the Greeks,[d] to remove them far from their own borders. 7 I am going to stir them

up from where you sold them, and bring your actions back upon your
own heads. 8 I will sell your sons and daughters to the people of Judah,
who will trade them to the Sabeans,[e] a faraway nation; Yahweh has
spoken."
9 Proclaim this among the nations:
Prepare for war;[f]
stir up the warriors.
Let all the fighting men draw near;
let them come up.
10 Hammer your plowshares into swords
and your pruning hooks into spears;[g]
let the weakling say, "I am a warrior."
11 Come quickly, all you surrounding nations,
assemble in that place.
Yahweh, bring down your warriors!
12 Let the nations rouse themselves
and come up to the Valley of Jehoshaphat;
for there I will sit to judge
all the nations round about.
13 Put in the sickle,
for the harvest is ripe.
Come, tread,
for the winepress is full.
The vats overflow,
for their wickedness is great.[h]
14 Multitudes, multitudes
in the valley of decision!
For the day of Yahweh is near
in the valley of decision.
15 Sun and moon grow dark,
and the stars withdraw their shining.
16 Yahweh roars from Zion
and utters his voice from Jerusalem,
and the heavens and the earth shake.

But Yahweh is a refuge for his people,
a stronghold for the children of Israel.
17 "So you will know that I am Yahweh your God,
dwelling in Zion, my holy mountain.
Jerusalem will be holy,
and strangers will never again pass through it.
18 "On that day
the mountains will drip new wine,
the hills will run with milk,
and all the dry riverbeds of Judah
will carry water.
A spring will rise from Yahweh's house
and irrigate the Valley of Shittim.[i]
19 Egypt will be made a desolation,
Edom a wasted wilderness,
because of the violence against Judah's people,
whose innocent blood they shed in their land.
20 But Judah will be inhabited forever,
and Jerusalem from generation to generation.
21 I will avenge their blood,
which I have not yet avenged;[j]
for Yahweh dwells in Zion."

Notes

- a (3:1) Chapter 3 is chapter 4 in the Hebrew text.
- b (3:2) The name means "Yahweh judges" (compare "the valley of decision" in verse 14). Since at least the fourth century AD it has been identified with the Kidron Valley east of Jerusalem, but the name may be symbolic.
- c (3:5) Or "palaces."
- d (3:6) Hebrew "the sons of the Yevanim," the Ionians (compare Daniel 8:21).
- e (3:8) The people of Sheba in southwest Arabia, traders on the incense routes.
- f (3:9) Hebrew "Sanctify war," since battle was begun with religious rites.
- g (3:10) The reverse of Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3.
- h (3:13) Compare Revelation 14:14–20.
- i (3:18) The name means "acacias." Perhaps the dry wadi running from Jerusalem toward the Dead Sea (compare Ezekiel 47:1–12; Zechariah 14:8).

- j (3:21) Or “I will declare innocent their blood that I had not declared innocent.” The Septuagint and Syriac read “I will avenge their blood and will not leave it unpunished.”

Amos

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The words of Amos, one of the sheep breeders[a] of Tekoa, which
he saw concerning Israel in the days of Uzziah king of Judah and in
the days of Jeroboam son of Joash, king of Israel, two years before
the earthquake.[b]
2 He said:
"Yahweh roars from Zion
and from Jerusalem lifts his voice;
the shepherds' pastures mourn,
and the summit of Carmel withers."
3 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Damascus,
yes, for four,[c] I will not turn it back;
because with sledges of iron
they threshed Gilead.
4 So I will hurl a fire at Hazael's dynasty,
and it will devour Ben-hadad's strongholds.[d]
5 I will smash Damascus's gate bolt,
and remove the king[e] who sits in the Valley of Aven
and the scepter-bearer in Beth-eden;
and Aram's population will be deported to Kir,"
says Yahweh.
6 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Gaza,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because they carried off whole communities[f] as captives
to hand them over to Edom.
7 So I will send a fire upon the wall of Gaza,
and it will consume her fortresses.

8 I will remove the king of Ashdod,
and the scepter-bearer of Ashkelon;
I will strike Ekron with my hand,
and the Philistines who remain will die,"
says the Lord Yahweh.
9 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Tyre,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because they delivered up whole communities to Edom
and did not remember the covenant of brothers.
10 So I will send a fire upon the wall of Tyre,
and it will consume her fortresses."
11 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Edom,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because he hunted his brother[g] with the sword
and stifled all compassion;
his anger tore without ceasing,
and he kept his fury forever.
12 So I will send a fire upon Teman,
and it will consume the fortresses of Bozrah."
13 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of the Ammonites,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because they ripped open the pregnant women of Gilead
to widen their own border.
14 So I will set Rabbah's[h] wall ablaze,
and the fire will devour her strongholds,
amid war cries on the day of combat,
amid a gale on the day of the tempest.
15 Into exile their king[i] shall go,
he and his princes with him,"
says Yahweh.

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew noqedim, used also of Mesha king of Moab (2 Kings 3:4); perhaps an owner or manager of flocks rather than a simple herdsman (compare 7:14). Tekoa was a village about 10 miles (16 kilometers) south of Jerusalem.
- b (1:1) A major earthquake remembered long afterward (Zechariah 14:5); archaeological evidence at several sites, including Hazor, suggests a date of about 760 BC.
- c (1:3) A numerical saying meaning "for sin upon sin," building to a climax (compare Proverbs 30:15–31). "It" is probably the punishment.
- d (1:4) Hazael and his son Ben-hadad were kings of Aram (Syria) in the ninth century BC (2 Kings 8:7–15; 13:3, 24).
- e (1:5) Or "the inhabitants." Aven ("wickedness") and Beth-eden ("house of delight") may be mocking names. Kir was the original homeland of the Arameans (9:7); they were exiled there by Tiglath-pileser III in 732 BC (2 Kings 16:9).
- f (1:6) Hebrew "a complete exile," sparing no one; likewise in verse 9.
- g (1:11) Edom descended from Esau, the brother of Jacob (Genesis 25:19–34; 36:1).
- h (1:14) The capital of Ammon, the site of modern Amman in Jordan.
- i (1:15) Or "Milcom," the god of the Ammonites (so some Greek manuscripts; compare Jeremiah 49:3).

Chapter 2

1 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Moab,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because he burned the bones of the king of Edom
to lime.[a]
2 So I will send a fire upon Moab,
and it will consume the fortresses of Kerioth;[b]
Moab will die amid tumult,
with shouting and the blast of the horn.
3 From among them I will cut off the judge[c]
and slay all her princes along with him,"
says Yahweh.
4 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Judah,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because they have rejected the law of Yahweh
and have not kept his statutes,
and their lies[d] have led them astray,
the lies after which their fathers walked.

5 So I will send a fire upon Judah,
and it will consume the fortresses of Jerusalem."
6 This is what Yahweh says:
"For three transgressions of Israel,
yes, for four, I will not turn it back;
because they sell the righteous for silver,
and the needy for a pair of sandals—
7 They trample the heads of the poor
into the dirt[e]
and shove the humble aside;
a man and his father visit the same girl,
and so profane my holy name;
8 they stretch out beside every altar
on garments taken in pledge,[f]
and in the house of their God they drink
the wine of those who have been fined.
9 "Yet I was the one who wiped out the Amorites ahead of them,
though they stood as tall as cedars
and were as sturdy as oak trees;
I wiped out their fruit on top
and their roots below.
10 And it was I who brought you up out of the land of Egypt
and led you forty years in the wilderness,
to take possession of the land of the Amorite.
11 I raised up prophets from among your sons,
and Nazirites from among your young men.[g]
Is that not so, people of Israel?"
declares Yahweh.
12 "But you gave the Nazirites wine to drink,
and you ordered the prophets,
'You shall not prophesy.'
13 Look, I am going to make you groan where you are,[h]
as a wagon groans
that is loaded with sheaves.

14 Speed will not help the swift escape;
the strong will not summon their power,
and the warrior will not rescue his life.
15 The one who handles the bow will not hold firm;
the fleet-footed will not get away,
and the one who rides the horse will not save his life.
16 The stoutest-hearted among the mighty
shall run away naked in that day,"
declares Yahweh.

Notes

- a (2:1) A desecration of the dead, denying the king rest in his grave.
- b (2:2) A city of Moab, mentioned also on the Mesha Stone (about 840 BC).
- c (2:3) That is, the king or chief ruler.
- d (2:4) That is, their false gods.
- e (2:7) Or "who pant after the dust of the earth on the head of the poor," that is, who covet even the dust the poor put on their heads in mourning.
- f (2:8) The law required that a cloak taken in pledge be returned by nightfall (Exodus 22:26–27; Deuteronomy 24:12–13).
- g (2:11) People under a vow of separation to God, who abstained from wine (Numbers 6:1–21; Judges 13:4–5).
- h (2:13) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; perhaps "I will make you totter" or "I will split the ground beneath you."

Chapter 3

1 Listen to this message Yahweh has announced against you, Israelites,
against the entire clan I led out of Egypt:
2 "You alone have I known[a]
of all the families of the earth;
therefore I will punish you
for all your iniquities."
3 Do two walk together
unless they have arranged to meet?
4 Does a lion roar in the forest
when he has no prey?
Does a young lion cry out from his den
unless he has caught something?

5 Does a bird fall into a snare on the ground
when there is no bait[b] for it?
Does a trap spring up from the ground
when it has taken nothing?
6 Is a horn blown in a city
and the people not tremble?
Does disaster come to a city
unless Yahweh has done it?
7 Surely the Lord Yahweh will not do a thing
unless he has disclosed his counsel[c]
to his servants the prophets.
8 The lion has roared;
who will not fear?
The Lord Yahweh has spoken;
who can but prophesy?
9 Announce to the strongholds of Ashdod[d]
and to the strongholds of Egypt,
"Gather on Samaria's hills
and witness the great panic inside her
and the cruelty within her."
10 "They do not know how to do right," declares Yahweh,
"those who store up violence and robbery in their fortresses."
11 Therefore this is what the Lord Yahweh declares:
"An enemy will encircle the country;
he will pull down your defenses,
and your strongholds will be looted."
12 This is what Yahweh says:
"As a shepherd snatches out of the lion's mouth
a pair of legs or a piece of an ear,[e]
so will the children of Israel be snatched away, those who sit in Samaria
on the edge of a couch
and on the cushions[f] of a bed."
13 "Hear and testify against the house of Jacob,"
declares the Lord Yahweh, the God of Armies,[g]

14 “For in the day I call Israel to account for his crimes,
I will also deal with the altars of Bethel;
the altar’s horns[h] will be lopped off
and drop to the ground.
15 I will strike the winter house along with the summer house,
and the houses of ivory[i] will perish,
and the great houses will come to an end,”
declares Yahweh.

Notes

- a (3:2) That is, chosen and cared for (compare Genesis 18:19).
- b (3:5) Or “no trap.”
- c (3:7) Hebrew sod, the confidential deliberation of a council (compare Jeremiah 23:18, 22).
- d (3:9) The Septuagint reads “Assyria.”
- e (3:12) A shepherd brought such remains to prove that an animal had been killed by a wild beast and not stolen (Exodus 22:13).
- f (3:12) The meaning of the Hebrew word (demesheq) is uncertain; traditionally “Damascus,” perhaps “damask” or “the leg.”
- g (3:13) Hebrew ʾelohe hatstseḇaʾoth, traditionally “God of hosts,” the God who commands the armies of heaven and of Israel.
- h (3:14) The projections at the four corners of the altar, which a fugitive might grasp for sanctuary (1 Kings 1:50).
- i (3:15) Houses with ivory inlay; many carved ivories of this period have been excavated at Samaria.

Chapter 4

1 Hear this word, you cows of Bashan[a]
who are on the mountain of Samaria,
who oppress the poor, who crush the needy,
who say to your lords,[b] “Bring, and let us drink!”
2 The Lord Yahweh has sworn by his holiness
that the days are surely coming upon you
when they will take you away with hooks,
the last of you with fishhooks.
3 And you will go out through the breaches,
each straight ahead,

and you will be cast out toward Harmon,”[c]
declares Yahweh.
4 “Enter Bethel and rebel;
enter Gilgal and rebel more;
bring sacrifices at dawn each day,
and your tithes every third day;[d]
5 burn leavened bread as a thank offering,
and announce your freewill offerings, make them known;
for that is what you love, people of Israel!”
declares the Lord Yahweh.
6 “I gave you cleanness of teeth[e] in all your cities,
and lack of bread in all your places;
but you have not come back to me,”
declares Yahweh.
7 “I also held back the rain from you
while there were three months yet until harvest;
on one town I made it rain,
and on another town I made it not rain;
one plot was rained on,
and the plot that got no rain dried up.
8 Two or three towns staggered to another town
to drink water and could not get enough;
but you have not come back to me,”
declares Yahweh.
9 “I struck you with scorching and mildew;
the locust ate your gardens and your vineyards,
your figs and your olives, many as they were;
but you have not come back to me,”
declares Yahweh.
10 “I sent pestilence on you in the way of Egypt;
with the sword I slew your young men,
and your horses were taken captive,
and I made the stink of your camps go up even into your nostrils;
but you have not come back to me,”
declares Yahweh.

11 "I overthrew some of you,
as God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah,
and you were like a burning stick snatched from the fire;
but you have not come back to me,"
declares Yahweh.
12 "Therefore this is what I will do to you, Israel;
because I will do this to you,
prepare to meet your God, Israel!"
13 For look—the one who shapes the mountains and creates the wind,
who tells mankind what he is thinking,[f]
who turns dawn to darkness
and strides upon the high places of the earth—
Yahweh, the God of Armies, is his name!

Notes

- a (4:1) Bashan, east of the Sea of Galilee, was famous for its rich pastures and well-fed cattle (Deuteronomy 32:14; Psalm 22:12). The phrase is addressed to the wealthy women of Samaria.
- b (4:1) Hebrew ʾadonehem, "their lords," that is, their husbands (compare Genesis 18:12).
- c (4:3) The meaning is uncertain; perhaps a place name, or (with a slight change) "Mount Hermon."
- d (4:4) The law required tithes yearly or every three years (Deuteronomy 14:22–29); Amos mocks their zeal.
- e (4:6) That is, nothing to eat.
- f (4:13) Or "what his own (God's) thought is." Verse 13 is the first of three hymn fragments in Amos (compare 5:8–9; 9:5–6).

Chapter 5

1 Hear this word, which I lift up over you as a lament, house of Israel:
2 "Fallen, no more to rise,
is the young woman Israel;[a]
forsaken on her own soil,
with no one to raise her up."
3 For this is what the Lord Yahweh says:
"The city that marched out a thousand strong
will have a hundred left,

and the one that marched out a hundred strong
will have ten left, for the house of Israel."
4 For this is what Yahweh says to the house of Israel:
"Seek me and live;
5 Do not go seeking Bethel;
do not enter Gilgal;
do not pass over to Beersheba;
for Gilgal shall go off into exile,[b]
and Bethel shall become nothing."[c]
6 Look for Yahweh, and you will live,
or he will sweep through Joseph's house like a blaze,
and it will burn with nobody able to put it out at Bethel—
7 you who turn justice into wormwood[d]
and fling righteousness to the ground!
8 He who made the Pleiades and Orion,[e]
who turns deep darkness into morning
and darkens day into night,
who calls for the waters of the sea
and pours them out on the face of the earth—
Yahweh is his name—
9 who flashes destruction upon the strong,
so that destruction comes upon the fortress.
10 They hate the one who reproves in the gate,[f]
and they loathe the one who speaks with integrity.
11 Because you stamp on the poor
and extract grain taxes from them,
you have built mansions of carved stone,
yet you will never live in them;
you have set out lovely vineyards,
yet you will never drink the wine.
12 For I am aware of your many rebellions
and your enormous sins—
you oppress the innocent, accept payoffs,
and push the poor aside in court.

13 So the wise keep quiet at such a time,
because the times are wicked.
14 Seek good and not evil,
that you may live;
and so Yahweh, the God of Armies, will be with you,
as you have said.
15 Hate evil and love good,
and establish justice in the gate;
it may be that Yahweh, the God of Armies,
will be gracious to the remnant of Joseph.
16 So this is what Yahweh, the God of Armies, the Lord, says:
"Wailing will fill every plaza,
and in every street they will cry, 'Oh no! Oh no!'
Farmers will be summoned to grieve,
and professional mourners[g] to wail;
17 and in all vineyards there will be wailing,
for I will pass through your midst,"
says Yahweh.
18 Disaster for you who yearn for Yahweh's day!
What will Yahweh's day mean for you?
It will be dark, not bright—
19 as when a man escapes a lion
only to be met by a bear,
or goes indoors, rests a hand on the wall,
and is bitten by a snake.
20 Is not the day of Yahweh darkness, not light,
gloom with no brightness in it?
21 "I hate, I reject your festivals,
and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies.[h]
22 Though you bring me whole burnt offerings and your gifts of grain,
they will not please me;
the fat beasts of your peace offerings
I will not regard.
23 Remove from my presence the clamor of your songs;
I will not hear the music of your lyres.

24 Instead, let justice surge like the waters,
and righteousness like a stream that never fails.[i]
25 "Was it sacrifices and grain offerings that you brought me
those forty years in the wilderness, house of Israel?
26 Now you shall carry off Sakkuth your king
and Kaiwan, your star god,[j] your idols
that you fashioned for yourselves;
27 therefore I will send you into exile beyond Damascus,"
says Yahweh, whose name is the God of Armies.

Notes

- a (5:2) Hebrew "the virgin Israel," a poetic personification of the nation. Verse 2 is in the limping rhythm of the Hebrew funeral lament (qinah).
- b (5:5) A wordplay in Hebrew: haggilgal galoh yigleh.
- c (5:5) Hebrew "will become aven (wickedness, nothingness)," alluding to the name Beth-aven (see the note at Hosea 4:15).
- d (5:7) A bitter-tasting plant, used figuratively for what is poisonous (compare 6:12).
- e (5:8) Hebrew kimah and kesil, two constellations, probably the Pleiades and Orion (compare Job 9:9; 38:31).
- f (5:10) The open area at the city gate where the elders sat to hear legal cases; likewise in verses 12 and 15.
- g (5:16) Professional mourners, often women (Jeremiah 9:17–20).
- h (5:21) Hebrew "I will not smell," alluding to the pleasing aroma of sacrifice (Leviticus 26:31).
- i (5:24) Hebrew naḥal ʾethan, a wadi that does not dry up in summer.
- j (5:26) Sakkuth and Kaiwan are Mesopotamian names for the planet Saturn, worshiped as a god. The Hebrew vowels (Sikkuth, Kiyyun) may be a deliberate distortion modeled on shiqquts, "detestable thing." The Septuagint reads "the tent of Moloch and the star of your god Raiphan," and is quoted in Acts 7:42–43. The verse may also be read as past: "You carried Sakkuth…"

Chapter 6

1 Disaster for those lounging comfortably in Zion
and those feeling safe on Samaria's mountain,
the famous leaders of the foremost nation,
the ones Israel's people turn to!
2 Cross over to Calneh and see;
go from there to Hamath the great;

then go down to Gath of the Philistines.
Are you better than these kingdoms?
Or is their territory greater than your territory?[a]
3 You who put off the day of disaster
bring near the seat of violence.
4 They lie on beds of ivory
and sprawl on their couches;
they eat lambs from the flock
and calves from the stall.
5 They improvise[b] to the sound of the harp;
like David they devise for themselves instruments of song.
6 They drink wine from bowls
and anoint themselves with the finest oils,
but they do not grieve over the ruin of Joseph.
7 So now they shall go into exile at the head of the exiles,
and the feasting of the loungers shall be gone.[c]
8 The Lord Yahweh has sworn by himself, declares Yahweh, the God of Armies:
"I abhor the pride of Jacob
and hate his fortresses;
and I will hand over the city and everything in it."
9 If ten men remain in one house, they will die.
10 And when a relative,[d] the one who burns the dead, picks up the body to carry it out of the house, he will say to whoever is in the innermost parts of the house, "Is anyone else with you?" and he will say, "No." Then he will say, "Hush! We must not mention the name of Yahweh."
11 For look, Yahweh commands,
and the great house will be struck into fragments,
and the small house into splinters.
12 Do horses run on rocks?
Does one plow the sea with oxen?[e]
But you have turned justice into poison
and the fruit of righteousness into wormwood—

13 you who rejoice in Lo-debar,[f]
who say, “Was it not by our own strength
that we took Karnaim for ourselves?”
14 “For look, I am raising up against you a nation, house of Israel,”
declares Yahweh, the God of Armies,
“and they will oppress you from Lebo-hamath[g]
to the Brook of the Arabah.”

Notes

- a (6:2) Calneh and Hamath, cities in northern Syria, and Gath, a Philistine city, were all conquered in the eighth century BC. Some reverse the last line: “Is your territory greater than theirs?”
- b (6:5) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; perhaps “strum” or “babble.”
- c (6:7) Hebrew marzeaḥ, a feast or banqueting association, often connected with funerary rites (compare Jeremiah 16:5).
- d (6:10) Hebrew dod, “uncle” or “kinsman.” The phrase that follows (meśarepho) is usually understood as “the one who burns him,” whether in cremation (unusual in Israel) or burning spices in his honor; the Hebrew of the verse is difficult.
- e (6:12) So by a different division of the Hebrew letters (babbaqar yam); the Hebrew text reads “Does one plow there with oxen?”
- f (6:13) Lo-debar means “nothing,” and Karnaim means “a pair of horns,” a symbol of strength; both were towns in Gilead, apparently recaptured by Jeroboam II (2 Kings 14:25).
- g (6:14) Hebrew “the entrance of Hamath,” the ideal northern border of Israel. The Brook of the Arabah was probably at the southern end of the Dead Sea. Compare 2 Kings 14:25.

Chapter 7

1 This is what the Lord Yahweh showed me: he was forming locusts when the late crop[a] was beginning to sprout, the late crop after the king’s mowing. 2 When the locusts had eaten every green thing in the country, I cried, “Lord Yahweh, please pardon! How will Jacob survive? He is so tiny.” 3 Yahweh relented concerning this. “It shall not be,” said Yahweh.

4 The Lord Yahweh showed me this: he was summoning a judgment of fire, and it consumed the vast deep[b] and began to consume the land. 5 Then I said, “Lord Yahweh, please stop! How can Jacob stand? He is so small.” 6 Yahweh relented concerning this. “This also shall not be,” said the Lord Yahweh.

7 He showed me this: there stood the Lord by a wall made true by a
plumb line,[c] and a plumb line was in his hand.
8 Yahweh asked me, "What are you looking at, Amos?" I answered,
"A plumb line." Then the Lord said, "Look, I am placing a plumb line
among my people Israel; I will no longer overlook them.
9 The high places of Isaac will be laid waste,
and the sanctuaries of Israel will be ruined,
and I will rise against the house of Jeroboam with the sword."
10 Then Amaziah, priest of Bethel, sent this message to Jeroboam,
Israel's king: "Amos is plotting against you right in the heart of Israel.
The country cannot endure everything he says. 11 For this is what
Amos has said: 'Jeroboam will die by the sword, and Israel will surely
go into exile away from its land.' " 12 And Amaziah said to Amos,
"Seer, go, run off to the land of Judah, and earn your bread there,
and prophesy there; 13 but never again prophesy at Bethel, for it is
the king's sanctuary and a royal house." 14 Amos answered Amaziah,
"I am no prophet, nor a prophet's son;[d] I am a herdsman and a
dresser of sycamore figs.[e] 15 But Yahweh took me from following the
flock, and Yahweh said to me, 'Go, prophesy to my people Israel.' 16
Now hear the word of Yahweh. You are saying, 'Prophesy no more
against Israel; stop dripping words[f] against Isaac's house.' 17 Therefore
Yahweh says: 'Your wife will become a prostitute in town; your
children will be killed by the sword; your land will be surveyed and
divided; you yourself will die in a foreign, unclean country,[g] and Israel
will certainly be taken from its homeland into exile.' "

Notes

- a (7:1) The crop that grew after the spring rains, in about March–April. The king apparently took the first cutting as a tax.
- b (7:4) Hebrew tehom, the subterranean waters thought to feed springs and rivers (Genesis 7:11).
- c (7:7) Hebrew ʾanak, a word occurring only here (four times). Traditionally "plumb line," but it is the Akkadian word for "tin," and some interpret "a wall of tin" as a symbol of weakness or of military defense; the meaning remains debated.
- d (7:14) Or "I was no prophet, nor a prophet's son." The Hebrew has no verb. "A prophet's son" means a member of a prophetic guild (compare 2 Kings 2:3–7).

- e (7:14) The fruit of the sycamore fig had to be slit or pinched to ripen; it grew in the lowlands, not at Tekoa itself.
- f (7:16) Hebrew "drip," that is, let words fall.
- g (7:17) That is, a foreign land.

Chapter 8

1 The Lord Yahweh showed me this: a basket of ripe fruit. 2 He asked,
"What are you looking at, Amos?" I answered, "A basket of ripe fruit."
Then Yahweh told me, "The end[a] has arrived for my people Israel; I
will no longer overlook them. 3 The songs of the temple[b] will become
wailings on that day," declares the Lord Yahweh. "The dead bodies
will be many, thrown out everywhere. Hush!"
4 Hear this, you who trample the needy
and would bring the poor of the land to an end,
5 who say, "When will the new moon pass,
so we can sell our grain?
When will the Sabbath be done,
so we can set out our wheat,
shrinking the measure and inflating the price,[c]
and tipping deceitful balances,
6 buying the poor with silver
and the destitute for a pair of sandals,
and selling even the wheat sweepings?"
7 Yahweh has sworn by the pride of Jacob:[d]
"Surely I will never forget any of their deeds.
8 Will not the land quake because of this,
and all its inhabitants mourn?
Will it not all rise up like the Nile,
heave, and subside like the river of Egypt?"
9 "In that day," declares the Lord Yahweh,
"I will bring the sun down at midday
and cover the earth with darkness while it is still day.[e]
10 I will convert your festivals into funerals
and all your songs into laments;
I will make everyone wear sackcloth
and shave every head;

I will make it a time of grieving, as for an only son,
and its finish will be a bitter day.
11 "Look, the days are coming," declares the Lord Yahweh,
"when I will send a famine on the land—
not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water,
but of hearing the words of Yahweh.
12 They will wander from sea to sea,
and from north to east they will run about
seeking the word of Yahweh,
but they will not find it.
13 On that day the lovely young women and the young men
will faint for thirst.
14 Those who swear by the guilt of Samaria,[f]
and say, 'As your god lives, Dan,'
and, 'As the way of Beersheba lives,'
will fall and never rise again."

Notes

- a (8:2) A wordplay in Hebrew between qayits, "summer fruit," and qets, "end." The fruit was gathered in August–September.
- b (8:3) Or "palace."
- c (8:5) Hebrew "making the ephah small and the shekel great," that is, giving short measure (the ephah was a dry measure of about two-thirds of a bushel, or 22 liters) and weighing the buyer's silver with an overweight shekel (normally about two-fifths of an ounce, or 11.5 grams).
- d (8:7) Perhaps a title of God himself (compare 1 Samuel 15:29), or spoken in irony of Israel's arrogance (6:8).
- e (8:9) A total eclipse of the sun was visible in the region on June 15, 763 BC, and is recorded in Assyrian sources.
- f (8:14) Or "by Ashimah of Samaria," a goddess (compare 2 Kings 17:30). Dan and Beersheba were sanctuaries at the northern and southern ends of the land.

Chapter 9

1 I saw the Lord standing by[a] the altar, and he said:
"Strike the tops of the pillars so the doorframes tremble,
and smash them down on everyone's heads;
the survivors I will slaughter with the sword.

No one will get away;
no one will escape.
2 Though they burrow into Sheol,
my hand will take them from there;
though they mount to the heavens,
I will pull them down from there.
3 Though they hide on Carmel's peak,
I will hunt them out and seize them there;
though they hide from my eyes on the floor of the sea,
I will command the serpent there to bite them.
4 And if they go into captivity before their enemies,
there I will command the sword, and it will kill them;
I will fix my eyes upon them
for harm and not for good."
5 The Lord Yahweh of Armies[b]—
at his touch the earth melts,
and all its inhabitants mourn;
the whole of it rises like the Nile
and falls back like the river of Egypt;
6 He constructs his upper chambers in the sky
and sets his dome[c] over the earth;
he summons the sea's waters
and pours them over the land's surface—
Yahweh is his name.
7 "Are you not like the Cushites[d] to me,
people of Israel?" declares Yahweh.
"Did I not bring Israel up from the land of Egypt,
and the Philistines from Caphtor,[e]
and the Arameans from Kir?
8 Look, the eyes of the Lord Yahweh are upon the sinful kingdom,
and I will destroy it from the face of the ground,
except that I will not utterly destroy the house of Jacob,"
declares Yahweh.
9 "For I am giving the command,
and I will sift Israel's house among all the nations,

as grain is sifted in a sieve,
and not one pebble will drop to the ground.
10 All the sinners of my people will die by the sword,
who say, 'Disaster will not overtake or meet us.'
11 "On that day I will lift up
David's collapsed shelter,[f]
mend its cracks,
restore its ruins,
and rebuild it as it was long ago,
12 so that they may take over what is left of Edom
and every nation that bears my name,"[g]
announces Yahweh, who will do this.
13 "See, days are coming," announces Yahweh,
"when the plowman will catch up with the harvester,
and the grape stomper with the one who sows seed;
the mountains will trickle with new wine,
and all the hills will run with it.[h]
14 I will bring back the captivity[i] of my people Israel;
they shall build the wasted cities and dwell in them;
they shall plant vineyards and drink the wine from them,
and lay out gardens and eat the fruit from them.
15 I will plant them on their land,
and they will never again be uprooted
from the land that I have given them,"
says Yahweh your God.

Notes

- a (9:1) Or "upon." The altar is probably that of Bethel.
- b (9:5) Hebrew YHWH hatstseḇaʾoth, traditionally "the LORD of hosts," the God who commands the armies of heaven and of Israel.
- c (9:6) Or "his band" or "his bundle"; the meaning of the Hebrew ʾaguddah is uncertain here.
- d (9:7) The people of the upper Nile region (ancient Nubia).
- e (9:7) Probably Crete.
- f (9:11) Hebrew sukkah, a hut or shelter, here a figure for the dynasty or kingdom of David in its weakened state.

- g (9:12) Hebrew “over whom my name is called,” marking them as his possession. The Septuagint, reading ʾadam (“humankind”) for ʾedom and yidreshu (“seek”) for yirshu (“possess”), has “so that the remnant of humankind, and all the nations upon whom my name is called, may seek me.” James quotes the verses in this Greek form at the Jerusalem council (Acts 15:16–17) to support the inclusion of the Gentiles.
- h (9:13) Hebrew “will melt.”
- i (9:14) Or “restore the fortunes.”

Obadiah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The vision of Obadiah.[a]
This is what the Lord Yahweh says about Edom—
a report we have heard from Yahweh,
and a messenger is sent out among the nations:
"Up! Let us go to war against her!"—
2 "Look, I am making you small among the nations;
you will be utterly despised.
3 The arrogance of your heart has deceived you,
you who dwell in the clefts of the rock,[b]
whose dwelling is on the heights,
who say in your heart,
'Who can bring me down to the ground?'
4 Though you fly high as the eagle,
though you place your nest among the stars,
even from there I will pull you down,"
declares Yahweh.
5 "Had thieves come to you,
or robbers in the night—
how you are ruined!—
would they not have stolen just enough for themselves?
Had grape pickers come to you,
would they not have left some gleanings?
6 How Esau has been ransacked,
his hidden treasures sought out!
7 Your confederates have pushed you to the frontier;
your friends have tricked you and prevailed against you;
your table companions lay a snare[c] under you—
he has no discernment.

8 On that day, declares Yahweh,
will I not destroy the wise men out of Edom,
and understanding out of the mount of Esau?[d]
9 Your warriors will be dismayed, Teman,[e]
so that every man will be cut off from the mount of Esau
by slaughter.
10 "Because of the violence done to your brother Jacob,
shame will cover you,
and you will be cut off forever.
11 In the day you stood by, at a distance,
in the day aliens took away his riches,
when foreigners passed through his gates
and threw lots over Jerusalem,
you as well were one of them.
12 But you should not have stared in glee[f] on your brother's day,
on the day of his disaster;
you should not have exulted over Judah's people
in the day of their destruction,
nor opened wide your mouth
in the day of trouble.
13 You should not have entered my people's gate
in the day of their calamity;
you, of all people, should not have gazed on his misery
in the day of his calamity;
you should not have reached for his goods
in the day of his calamity.[g]
14 You should never have waited at the fork in the road[h]
to kill his escaping refugees,
or surrendered his survivors
on the day of disaster.
15 "For the day of Yahweh is near
upon all the nations.
As you have done, it will be done to you;
your deeds will return on your own head.

16 For as you have drunk on my holy mountain,[i]
so all the nations will drink continually;
they will drink and swallow,
and will be as though they had never been.
17 But on Mount Zion there will be those who escape,
and it will be holy,
and the house of Jacob will possess its own possessions.[j]
18 Jacob's family will become a blaze,
Joseph's family a flame,
and Esau's family dry straw;
they will ignite it and burn it up,
and no one in Esau's family will survive.
Yahweh has said so.
19 "The people of the Negev[k] shall take the mount of Esau as their own,
and those of the Shephelah[l] the Philistines' land;
Ephraim's fields and Samaria's fields they shall possess,
and Benjamin shall have Gilead.
20 The exiles of this army of Israel's children
shall own Canaanite land up to Zarephath,[m]
and Jerusalem's exiles in Sepharad[n]
shall have the towns of the Negev.
21 Deliverers[o] will go up on Mount Zion
to rule the mount of Esau,
and the kingdom will be Yahweh's.

Notes

- a (1:1) The name means "servant of Yahweh." Nothing else is known of the prophet; he is not to be identified with the Obadiah of 1 Kings 18.
- b (1:3) Hebrew sela[ʿ], "rock," perhaps also alluding to Sela, an Edomite stronghold (2 Kings 14:7). Edom's mountain strongholds, south and east of the Dead Sea, were hard to reach.
- c (1:7) The meaning of the Hebrew mazor is uncertain; perhaps "a net" or "a wound." The Hebrew text reads "your bread"; some, with a small addition, read "those who eat your bread."
- d (1:8) Edom was proverbial for its wisdom (Jeremiah 49:7; compare Job 2:11, where Eliphaz is from Teman).
- e (1:9) A region or chief city of Edom.

- f (1:12) Hebrew “do not gloat.” The eight prohibitions in verses 12–14 have the force of a reproach for what Edom has already done.
- g (1:13) Hebrew ʾed, “calamity,” here three times, sounds like the name Edom.
- h (1:14) The meaning of the Hebrew pereq is uncertain; perhaps “the breach” or “the mountain pass.”
- i (1:16) “You” is plural here, perhaps addressing Judah, which drank the cup of God’s wrath (compare Jeremiah 25:15–29), or Edom, which caroused on Mount Zion after its fall.
- j (1:17) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Vulgate, with different vowels, read “will dispossess those who dispossessed them.”
- k (1:19) The dry southern region of Judah.
- l (1:19) The low hills between the Judean highlands and the coastal plain.
- m (1:20) A Phoenician town between Tyre and Sidon (1 Kings 17:9). The Hebrew of the first two lines is difficult.
- n (1:20) Probably Sardis in Asia Minor. In later Jewish usage the name was applied to Spain, hence “Sephardic” Jews.
- o (1:21) Or “Those who have been delivered,” following the Septuagint and Syriac.

Jonah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The word of Yahweh came to Jonah[a] son of Amittai: 2 "Up! Go to
Nineveh,[b] the great city, and denounce it, for their evil has risen up
before my face." 3 But Jonah got up to run away to Tarshish,[c] away
from the presence of Yahweh. He went down to Joppa[d] and found a
ship bound for Tarshish. He paid its fare and went down into it, to go
with them to Tarshish, away from Yahweh's presence.
4 Yahweh, however, hurled a great wind onto the sea, and so mighty
a storm arose on the sea that the ship was about to break apart.[e] 5
The sailors were terrified, and each man cried out to his own god.
They hurled the cargo on board into the sea to lighten the ship for
themselves. Jonah, though, had gone down into the hold of the vessel,
lain down, and fallen fast asleep. 6 The captain came to him and said,
"How can you be sleeping? Get up, call on your god! Perhaps that
god will give a thought to us, and we will not perish."
7 The sailors said to one another, "Let's cast lots to determine who is
responsible for this calamity." The lot was cast, and it landed on Jonah.
8 "Explain," they demanded, "who is responsible for this calamity?
What work do you do? Where is your home? What land are you from,
and who are your people?" 9 He told them, "I am a Hebrew, and I fear
Yahweh, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land." 10
At this the men were seized with a great fear, and said to him, "What
is this that you have done?" For the men knew he was fleeing from
Yahweh's presence, because he had told them.
11 So they said to him, "What must we do with you to make the sea
grow quiet around us?" For the sea kept getting rougher. 12 He told
them, "Lift me up and hurl me into the sea; then the sea will quiet
down around you. I know that it is my fault this mighty storm has
struck you." 13 Still the men rowed hard[f] to get back to land, but they

could not, for the sea was raging against them more and more. 14 So they cried out to Yahweh: "Please, Yahweh, do not let us perish for this man's life, and do not lay innocent blood on us; for you, Yahweh, have done just as you pleased." 15 Then they picked Jonah up and hurled him into the sea, and the sea stopped its raging. 16 And the men feared Yahweh with a great fear; they offered a sacrifice to Yahweh and made vows.

17 Yahweh appointed[g] a great fish[h] to swallow Jonah, and Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights.[i]

Notes

- a (1:1) The name means "dove." He is the prophet of 2 Kings 14:25, from Gath-hepher in Galilee.
- b (1:2) The capital of Assyria, on the east bank of the Tigris opposite modern Mosul, Iraq. Assyria was Israel's most feared enemy; it destroyed the northern kingdom in 722 BC.
- c (1:3) A distant port in the far west, probably Tartessus in southern Spain—the opposite direction from Nineveh.
- d (1:3) Modern Jaffa, part of Tel Aviv, on the Mediterranean coast.
- e (1:4) Hebrew "the ship thought to be broken." The verb "hurl" recurs in verses 5, 12, and 15.
- f (1:13) Hebrew "dug," a vivid word for straining at the oars.
- g (1:17) Hebrew manah, "appoint, assign." God likewise "appoints" the plant, the worm, and the east wind in chapter 4.
- h (1:17) Hebrew dag gadol, "a great fish." The Hebrew does not say "whale"; the Septuagint has kētos, "sea creature," the word used in Matthew 12:40, which older English versions rendered "whale." Jesus cites Jonah's three days and nights in the fish as "the sign of Jonah" (Matthew 12:39–41; Luke 11:29–32).
- i (1:17) English 1:17 is Hebrew 2:1.

Chapter 2

1 Then Jonah prayed to Yahweh his God from the belly of the fish.[a]

2 He said,

"In my distress I called out to Yahweh,
and he responded;
from the belly of Sheol[b] I screamed for help,
and you listened to my voice.

3 You flung me into the depths,
into the heart of the seas,

and the current swirled around me;
all your breakers and your billows
swept over me.
4 And I said, 'I am driven away
from before your eyes;
yet I will look again[c]
toward your holy temple.'
5 The waters closed over me up to the throat;[d]
the deep was all around me;
seaweed wrapped itself around my head.
6 To the roots of the mountains I went down;
the earth with its bars shut behind me forever;
yet you brought my life up from the pit,
Yahweh my God.
7 As my life was ebbing away,
I remembered Yahweh,
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
8 Those who cling to empty idols[e]
abandon their loyalty.[f]
9 But I will offer sacrifice to you
with a song of thanks;
the vow I made I will fulfill.
Deliverance belongs to Yahweh!"
10 Then Yahweh spoke to the fish, and it vomited Jonah out onto the dry land.

Notes

- a (2:1) English 2:1–10 is Hebrew 2:2–11. In 2:1 the Hebrew uses the feminine form dagah for "fish," elsewhere the masculine dag; the difference is probably only stylistic.
- b (2:2) The realm of the dead.
- c (2:4) So the Hebrew; with a slight change, "how shall I look again," as in Theodotion's Greek.
- d (2:5) Or "threatened my life." Hebrew nefesh can mean both "throat" and "life."
- e (2:8) Hebrew "worthless vanities."
- f (2:8) Or "forsake the one who is loyal to them," that is, God; Hebrew ḥesed.

Chapter 3

1 A second time the word of Yahweh came to Jonah: 2 "Up! Go to
Nineveh, the great city, and announce to it the word I am giving you."
3 So Jonah got up and went to Nineveh, as Yahweh had said. Now
Nineveh was a city great even to God,[a] a walk of three days across.[b]
4 Jonah began going into the city, one day's walk, and he called out,
"Forty days more, and Nineveh will be overturned!"[c]
5 The people of Nineveh believed God. They called a fast and put on
sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least. 6 The news reached
Nineveh's king, who stood up from his throne, removed his royal
robe, wrapped himself in sackcloth, and sat in the dust. 7 And he
had a proclamation cried through Nineveh: "By decree of the king
and his nobles: Let neither human nor beast, herd nor flock, taste
anything. Let them not graze or drink water. 8 Let human and beast
alike be covered with sackcloth, and let them call to God with all their
strength. Let each one turn from his evil ways and from the violence
that is in his hands. 9 Who can tell? Perhaps God will turn back and
relent,[d] and turn away from the heat of his anger, and we will not
perish."
10 God saw their deeds—that they had turned back from their wicked
conduct—and God relented of the harm he had threatened to do to
them, and did not do it.

Notes

- a (3:3) Hebrew "a great city to God," possibly an idiom for "an exceedingly great city."
- b (3:3) Hebrew "a journey of three days," about 60 miles (100 kilometers); perhaps the circuit of greater Nineveh and its districts, or the time needed to visit it all. The walls of ancient Nineveh enclosed about 1,850 acres (750 hectares).
- c (3:4) Hebrew haphak, the word used of the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:25), but which can also mean "turned around, changed."
- d (3:9) Or "change his mind." Compare Joel 2:14.

Chapter 4

1 But to Jonah this seemed a great evil, and he was furious.[a] 2 He prayed
to Yahweh and said, "Ah, Yahweh, is this not just what I said when I
was still back home? That is why I made haste to run off to Tarshish.

For I knew you were a God gracious and merciful, long-suffering and rich in steadfast love,[b] who relents over calamity. 3 So now, Yahweh, please take my life from me, for I am better off dead than alive." 4 And Yahweh said, "Is it right for you to be so angry?"

5 Jonah went out of the city and settled on its east side. There he made himself a shelter and sat in its shade to watch what would happen to the city. 6 Then Yahweh God appointed a plant[c] and made it grow up over Jonah, to be shade over his head, to rescue him from his misery.[d] Jonah was very glad because of the plant. 7 At daybreak the next day God sent a worm that gnawed the plant, and it dried up. 8 When the sun rose, God sent a sweltering east wind, and the sun beat on Jonah's head until he nearly fainted. He wished he were dead and said, "Death is better for me than life." 9 God asked Jonah, "Is your anger over the plant justified?" "It is," he replied. "I am so angry I could die." 10 Then Yahweh said, "You took pity on the plant, though you did not labor over it or make it grow. It came up in a night and perished in a night. 11 And may I not pity Nineveh, the great city, where there live over a hundred and twenty thousand human beings who cannot tell their right hand from their left,[e] and a great many beasts besides?"[f]

Notes

- a (4:1) Hebrew "it was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and it burned to him." The word "evil" echoes 3:8 and 3:10.
- b (4:2) Hebrew ḥesed. This confession echoes Exodus 34:6–7; compare Joel 2:13.
- c (4:6) Hebrew qiqayon, perhaps the castor-oil plant, which grows quickly and has broad leaves; older versions have "gourd."
- d (4:6) Hebrew raʿah, "evil," the same word as in 4:1.
- e (4:11) Perhaps meaning small children, or people without moral or religious understanding.
- f (4:11) The book ends with God's question unanswered.

Micah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Micah[a] of Moresheth[b] in the
days of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah,[c] which he saw
concerning Samaria and Jerusalem.

2 Listen, you peoples, all of you;
pay attention, earth, and all that fills it;
and let the Lord Yahweh be witness against you,
the Lord from his holy temple.

3 For look: Yahweh is coming out from his place;
he will come down and tread on the high places of the earth.

4 The mountains will melt beneath him,
and the valleys split open,
like wax in front of the fire,
like water poured down a slope.

5 All this is for Jacob's rebellion,
for the sins of the house of Israel.
What is Jacob's rebellion?
Is it not Samaria?
And what are Judah's high places?[d]
Are they not Jerusalem?

6 "So I will make Samaria a rubble heap in the open country,
a place for planting vines;
I will tumble her stones down into the valley
and lay bare her foundations.

7 All her carved idols will be smashed to bits,
all her earnings[e] burned with fire,
and all her images I will make a desolation;
for from a prostitute's fee she gathered them,
and to a prostitute's fee they will return."

8 Because of this I will mourn and howl;
I will walk around barefoot and stripped;
I will cry like the jackals
and moan like the owls.
9 Her wound is incurable;
it has spread to Judah;
it has arrived at my people's gate,
at Jerusalem itself.
10 Tell it not in Gath;[f]
weep not at all.
In Beth-leaphrah[g]
roll yourself in the dust.
11 Pass on your way,
inhabitants of Shaphir,[h] in shameful nakedness;
the inhabitants of Zaanan[i] do not come out;
Beth-ezel is wailing,
it will take away from you its support.[j]
12 For the inhabitants of Maroth[k] writhe, waiting for good,
because disaster has come down from Yahweh
to the gate of Jerusalem.
13 Hitch the horses to the chariot,
you residents of Lachish![l]
She was where Daughter Zion's sin began,
for Israel's rebellions were found in you.
14 So you will give parting gifts[m]
to Moresheth-gath;
the houses of Achzib[n] will be a deception
to Israel's kings.
15 Again I will bring a conqueror[o] upon you,
inhabitants of Mareshah;
the glory of Israel
will come to Adullam.[p]
16 Make yourself bald, shear your hair,
for the children you delight in;

widen your baldness like the vulture's,
since they are carried away from you as captives.

Notes

- a (1:1) The name is a short form of Micaiah, "Who is like Yahweh?" Compare 7:18.
- b (1:1) Moresheth-gath (1:14), a town in the Shephelah about 22 miles (35 kilometers) southwest of Jerusalem.
- c (1:1) Jotham reigned about 750–735 BC, Ahaz about 735–715 BC, and Hezekiah about 715–686 BC.
- d (1:5) So the Hebrew; the Septuagint and Targum read "what is the sin of the house of Judah?"
- e (1:7) Hebrew "hire," the wage of a prostitute, a figure for the wealth gained through idolatrous worship.
- f (1:10) An echo of David's lament in 2 Samuel 1:20. In verses 10–15 each town's name is the basis for a play on words, most of which cannot be carried into English.
- g (1:10) "House of dust."
- h (1:11) "Beautiful town."
- i (1:11) Sounds like the Hebrew for "come out."
- j (1:11) The meaning of the last line is uncertain.
- k (1:12) Sounds like the Hebrew for "bitterness."
- l (1:13) Lachish sounds like the Hebrew rekesh, "steeds." It was Judah's second city, besieged and taken by the Assyrian king Sennacherib in 701 BC.
- m (1:14) Or "a dowry," as for a bride leaving home.
- n (1:14) Achzib sounds like ʾakzab, "deceptive," a stream that dries up.
- o (1:15) Hebrew yoresh, "one who takes possession," a play on Mareshah.
- p (1:15) The cave where David hid from Saul (1 Samuel 22:1); Israel's leaders will be fugitives again.

Chapter 2

1 Woe to those who plan iniquity
and work out evil upon their beds!
When morning dawns they carry it out,
because it is in the power of their hand.
2 They covet fields and seize them,
and houses, and take them away;
they defraud a man and his household,
a man and his inheritance.
3 So this is what Yahweh says:
"See, I am devising evil against this clan,
and you will not slip your necks out from under it,

nor stride along with heads held high;
it will be a time of calamity.
4 In that day they will take up a taunt against you
and wail a bitter lament, saying,
'We are utterly ruined;
he exchanges the portion of my people.
How he takes it away from me!
To traitors he divides our fields.'
5 Therefore you will have no one to cast the measuring line by lot[a]
in the assembly of Yahweh.
6 "Stop your preaching," so they preach.[b]
"No one should preach about these things;
shame will never catch up with us."
7 Is this what you say, house of Jacob?
"Has Yahweh's Spirit run out of patience?
Is this how he acts?"
Do my words not benefit
the person who lives honestly?
8 But lately my people have risen up as an enemy.
You strip the robe off the cloak
from those who pass by trustingly,
like men returning from war.
9 The women of my people you drive out
from their pleasant houses;
from their young children you take away
my splendor forever.
10 Get up and go,
for this is no place of rest;
because of uncleanness it will destroy,
with a grievous destruction.
11 If a man walking in wind and falsehood should lie, saying,
"I will preach to you of wine and beer,"
he would be the preacher for this people!
12 "I will surely gather every one of you, Jacob;
I will assemble the survivors of Israel;

I will crowd them together like sheep in a fold,[c]
like livestock in their meadow;
the place will buzz with crowds.
13 The one who breaks open the way goes up ahead of them;
they burst out, they go through the gate
and leave by it.
Their king goes on in front of them,
Yahweh at their head."

Notes

- a (2:5) That is, no share when the land is divided again.
- b (2:6) Hebrew naṭaph, "drip," used of prophetic speech, as in Amos 7:16. The Hebrew of verses 6–11 is difficult in places.
- c (2:12) Hebrew Bozrah, here probably "an enclosure," though Bozrah was also a city of Edom famous for its sheep.

Chapter 3

1 Then I said:
Hear me, you chiefs of Jacob,
you governors of Israel's house!
Shouldn't you understand justice?
2 You despise good and adore evil;
you peel the hide from my people[a]
and the meat from their bones,
3 you devour my people's flesh,
skin them alive,
smash their bones,
and carve them up like cuts for the pot,
like meat for a kettle.
4 Then they will cry to Yahweh,
but he will not answer them;
he will hide his face from them at that time,
because they have made their deeds evil.
5 This is what Yahweh says concerning the prophets
who lead my people astray,
who, when they have something to chew,
cry "Peace!"

but declare holy war against anyone
who puts nothing in their mouths:
6 So night will fall on you, and no vision come;
dark will it be for you, and no divining;
the sun will set upon the prophets,
and the daylight turn black above them.
7 Shamed will be the seers
and abashed the diviners;
all of them will cover their lips,[b]
for God gives no answer.
8 But as for me, I am filled with power,
with the Spirit of Yahweh,
with justice and with might,
to declare to Jacob his rebellion
and to Israel his sin.
9 Hear this, heads of the house of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel,
who abhor justice
and twist all that is straight,
10 who build Zion with bloodshed
and Jerusalem with wrong.
11 Her heads give judgment for a bribe,
her priests teach for a fee,
her prophets divine for money;
yet they lean on Yahweh and say,
"Is not Yahweh in our midst?
No disaster will come upon us."
12 So on your account
Zion will be plowed like a field,
Jerusalem made a mound of rubble,
and the mountain of the house a forest height.[c]

Notes

- a (3:2) Hebrew "from them."
- b (3:7) Hebrew "mustache," a gesture of mourning or shame (Leviticus 13:45).

- c (3:12) This verse is quoted in Jeremiah 26:18, about a century later, where the elders recall that Hezekiah heeded it and sought Yahweh's favor.

Chapter 4

1 In the days to come[a]
the mountain of Yahweh's house
shall stand firm as the highest of the mountains,
lifted up above the hills,
and peoples shall stream to it.
2 Many nations will come, saying,
"Come, let's go up Yahweh's mountain,
to the temple of Jacob's God,
that he may teach us his ways
and we may follow his paths."
Teaching[b] will come out of Zion,
and Yahweh's word from Jerusalem.
3 He will arbitrate among many peoples
and settle quarrels among powerful distant nations;
they will beat their swords into plowshares
and their spears into pruning hooks;
nation will not lift a sword at nation,
and they will no longer learn how to fight.
4 Everyone will sit under their own grapevine and fig tree,
unafraid,
for Yahweh of Armies[c] has promised it.
5 Though every people marches
in the name of its own god,
we will march in the name of Yahweh our God
for all time.
6 "In that day," declares Yahweh,
"I will gather the lame
and assemble the scattered,
those whom I have afflicted.
7 The lame I will make a remnant,
and the outcast a mighty nation;

and Yahweh will reign over them on Mount Zion
from now on and forever.
8 And you, tower of the flock,[d]
hill[e] of Daughter Zion,
to you it will come—
the former dominion will return,
the kingdom of Daughter Jerusalem."
9 Why do you cry out now?
Have you no king?
Has your adviser died,
that agony seizes you like a woman giving birth?
10 Writhe and groan,[f] Daughter Zion,
like a woman giving birth;
for now you must go out from the town
and lodge in the countryside;
you will go to Babylon.
There you will be rescued;
there Yahweh will redeem you
from the grip of your enemies.
11 Now many nations
have assembled against you,
saying, "Let her be desecrated,
and let us feast our eyes on Zion."
12 But they do not know
the thoughts of Yahweh;
they do not grasp his purpose,
how he has bundled them like sheaves for the threshing floor.
13 Rise up and thresh, Daughter Zion,
for I will make your horn iron
and your hoofs bronze;
you will crush many peoples,
and devote their gain to Yahweh,[g]
their wealth to the Lord of all the earth.

Notes

- a (4:1) Verses 1–3 are nearly identical to Isaiah 2:2–4; Micah and Isaiah were contemporaries.
- b (4:2) Hebrew torah.
- c (4:4) Hebrew YHWH tsebaʾot, traditionally "the Lord of hosts": Yahweh as commander of the armies of heaven and of Israel.
- d (4:8) Hebrew Migdal-eder, perhaps a watchtower over Jerusalem; compare Genesis 35:21.
- e (4:8) Hebrew Ophel, the fortified hill south of the temple mount.
- f (4:10) The meaning of the Hebrew verb is uncertain; perhaps "push."
- g (4:13) Hebrew "devote to destruction" (ḥerem), here meaning to dedicate the plunder wholly to God.

Chapter 5

1 Now muster your troops, daughter of troops;[a]
a siege is laid against us;
with a rod they strike on the cheek
the judge of Israel.
2 But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,[b]
small among Judah's clans,
from you will come out for me
the future ruler of Israel,
whose roots reach back
to ancient times.[c]
3 Therefore he will give them up until the time
when she who is in labor has given birth;
then the rest of his brothers will return
to the people of Israel.
4 He will stand and shepherd his flock in the strength of Yahweh,
in the majesty of the name of Yahweh his God.
And they will dwell secure, for now he will be great
to the ends of the earth.
5 And he shall be our peace.[d]
When Assyria invades our land
and marches over our citadels,
we will set up seven shepherds against it,
yes, eight princes of the people.[e]

6 They will shepherd the land of Assyria with the sword,
the land of Nimrod[f] at its gates;[g]
he will deliver us from Assyria
when it comes into our land
and treads within our borders.
7 Then the remnant of Jacob will be
among many peoples
like dew from Yahweh,
like showers on the grass,
which wait for no one
and do not linger for mortals.
8 And the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,
in the midst of many peoples,
like a lion among the animals of the woods,
like a young lion among the sheepfolds,
which, when it goes through, treads down and mauls,
and none can deliver.
9 Let your hand be lifted over your foes,
and may all your enemies be cut off!
10 "In that day," declares Yahweh,
"I will cut off your horses from among you
and destroy your chariots;
11 I will cut off the cities of your land
and tear down all your strongholds;
12 I will cut off the sorceries in your hand,
and soothsayers you will have no more;
13 I will cut off your carved images
and your sacred pillars from among you,
and never again will you bow
before what your own hands have made;
14 I will tear out your Asherah poles[h] from your midst
and demolish your towns.[i]
15 In anger and fury I will take revenge
on the nations that did not listen."

Notes

- a (5:1) English 5:1 is Hebrew 4:14. The meaning of the first line is uncertain; perhaps "gash yourself, daughter of raiders."
- b (5:2) English 5:2–15 is Hebrew 5:1–14; this verse is Hebrew 5:1. Ephrathah is the clan district around Bethlehem, the hometown of David (Ruth 4:11; 1 Samuel 17:12), about 6 miles (9 kilometers) south of Jerusalem. Matthew 2:6 quotes this verse, in a free form, as fulfilled in the birth of Jesus at Bethlehem; compare John 7:42.
- c (5:2) Or "from days of eternity." The phrase may refer to the ancient line of David or, as Christian interpreters have understood it, to the ruler's origin before time.
- d (5:5) Or "This one will be peace," or "This will be our peace."
- e (5:5) "Seven… eight" is a Hebrew idiom for "more than enough."
- f (5:6) The legendary founder of Mesopotamian cities (Genesis 10:8–12).
- g (5:6) So the Hebrew; with a slight change, "with the drawn sword."
- h (5:14) Wooden cult objects associated with the goddess Asherah.
- i (5:14) Or, with a slight change, "your idols."

Chapter 6

1 Hear now what Yahweh is saying:
"Rise, plead your case before the mountains,
and let the hills hear your voice."
2 Hear, you mountains, Yahweh's lawsuit,[a]
you enduring foundations of the earth;
for Yahweh has a case against his people,
and with Israel he will argue it.
3 "My people, what have I done to you?
How have I worn you out? Answer me!
4 I brought you out of Egypt
and freed you from the land of slavery;
I sent Moses ahead of you,
with Aaron and Miriam.
5 My people, recall now
what Balak, Moab's king, schemed,
what reply Balaam son of Beor gave him,[b]
and all that took place between Shittim and Gilgal,[c]
that you may know the righteous acts[d] of Yahweh."
6 With what shall I come before Yahweh
and bow down to God on high?

Shall I come before him with burnt offerings,
with calves a year old?
7 Is Yahweh delighted by rams in their thousands,
by oil flowing in ten thousand streams?
Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion,
the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?
8 He has shown you, human being,[e] what is good;
what does Yahweh require of you
except to act justly, to cherish loyal love,[f]
and to live humbly[g] with your God?
9 Yahweh's voice cries out to the city—
and it is wise to revere your name:[h]
"Hear this, tribe, and the one who assigned it![i]
10 Can I forget[j] the treasures gained by wickedness
in the house of the wicked,
and the short measure[k] that is accursed?
11 Shall I acquit the one with crooked scales,
with a bag of false weights?
12 Her rich are full of violence;
her inhabitants speak lies,
and their tongue is deceit in their mouths.
13 So I in turn have begun to strike you,[l]
to lay you waste because of your sins.
14 You will eat but not be satisfied,
and hunger[m] will remain within you;
you will put things aside but not save them,
and what you save I will give to the sword.
15 You will plant but never harvest;
you will press olives but never rub on the oil,
and crush grapes but never drink wine.
16 For you have kept the statutes of Omri[n]
and all the practices of Ahab's house,
and you have walked in their counsels;
so I will turn you into a wasteland

and your[o] people into something to hiss at;
you will bear the scorn of my people."

Notes

- a (6:2) Hebrew rib, a formal legal complaint; the mountains and the foundations of the earth are summoned as witnesses (compare Deuteronomy 32:1; Isaiah 1:2).
- b (6:5) See Numbers 22–24.
- c (6:5) Shittim was Israel's last camp east of the Jordan (Numbers 25:1; Joshua 3:1); Gilgal its first camp west of it (Joshua 4:19).
- d (6:5) Or "saving acts."
- e (6:8) Hebrew ʾadam, "human being."
- f (6:8) Hebrew ḥesed, loyal and steadfast love.
- g (6:8) Or "carefully, attentively."
- h (6:9) So the Septuagint, reading the Hebrew with different vowels; the Masoretic Text reads "sees."
- i (6:9) The meaning of the Hebrew of this line is uncertain; perhaps "Hear, tribe and assembly of the city."
- j (6:10) The Hebrew of this line is uncertain.
- k (6:10) Hebrew "the lean ephah." The ephah was a dry measure of about two-thirds of a bushel (22 liters); merchants used undersized measures to cheat buyers.
- l (6:13) Or, following the Septuagint, "I have made you sick by striking you."
- m (6:14) The meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.
- n (6:16) Omri and his son Ahab, kings of Israel in the ninth century BC, were remembered for Baal worship and injustice (1 Kings 16–21).
- o (6:16) Hebrew "her."

Chapter 7

1 Woe is me! For I have become
like one at the gathering of summer fruit,
like the gleaning after the grape harvest:
no cluster to eat,
no early fig that I crave.
2 The faithful have perished from the land,
and there is no one upright among humankind;
all of them lie in ambush for blood;
each hunts his brother with a net.
3 Their hands are skilled at evil;
the official asks for gifts,
the judge for a bribe,

and the great man speaks out what his greed desires—
so they weave it together.
4 The best of them is like a briar,
the most upright worse than a thorn hedge.
The day of your watchmen,[a] your punishment, has come;
now will be their confusion.
5 Do not rely on a companion;
do not lean on a close friend;
even from her who lies in your arms
keep watch over the door of your lips.
6 For the son treats his father with contempt,
the daughter rises against her mother,
the daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law;
a man's enemies are those of his own house.[b]
7 But as for me, I will watch for Yahweh;
I will wait for the God of my salvation;
my God will hear me.
8 Rejoice not over me, you my foe!
I have fallen, yet I will get up;
I sit in the dark,
yet Yahweh is a light to me.
9 I will bear Yahweh's anger,
because I have sinned against him,
until he takes up my case
and brings about justice for me.
He will lead me out to the light;
I will see his saving righteousness.
10 Then my enemy will see it,
and disgrace will cover her,
the one who taunted me,
"Where is Yahweh your God?"
My eyes will gloat over her;
she will be trampled
like street mud.

11 A day to rebuild your walls!
On that day your borders will be pushed far outward.[c]
12 On that day they will come to you
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,[d]
and from Egypt to the River,[e]
from sea to sea and from mountain to mountain.
13 Yet the land will lie waste
on account of those who dwell in it,
the outcome of their doings.
14 Shepherd your people with your staff,
the flock that is your inheritance,
who live alone in a forest
in the midst of a fruitful land;[f]
let them graze in Bashan and Gilead
as in days long ago.
15 As in the days when you came out of the land of Egypt,
I will show them[g] marvelous things.
16 The nations will see and be ashamed
of all their might;
they will lay their hands on their mouths;
their ears will be deaf.
17 They will lick the dust like serpents,
like creatures that crawl on the ground;
they will shake as they leave their fortresses;
they will turn in terror to Yahweh our God,
and they will fear you.
18 Who is a God like you,[h]
pardoning iniquity
and passing over the rebellion
of the remnant of his inheritance?
He does not cling to his wrath for all time,
for faithful love is his delight.
19 He will once more show us mercy;
he will trample down our guilt.

You will hurl all our[i] sins
into the ocean's depths.
20 You will show faithfulness to Jacob,
steadfast love to Abraham,
as you swore to our ancestors
from the days of old.

Notes

- a (7:4) That is, the day the prophets warned of.
- b (7:6) Jesus quotes this verse in Matthew 10:35–36; compare Luke 12:53.
- c (7:11) Or "the decree will be far removed." The meaning is uncertain.
- d (7:12) Hebrew matsor, "Egypt" or "fortress," a play on words.
- e (7:12) The Euphrates.
- f (7:14) Hebrew Carmel, "garden land," perhaps also the mountain of that name.
- g (7:15) Hebrew "him."
- h (7:18) A play on Micah's name, "Who is like Yahweh?" (1:1).
- i (7:19) So the Septuagint, Syriac, and Vulgate; Hebrew "their."

Nahum

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 An oracle concerning Nineveh. The book of the vision of Nahum
the Elkoshite.[a]
2 Yahweh is a jealous God and an avenger;[b]
Yahweh avenges, and is a master of wrath.
Yahweh takes vengeance on his adversaries,
and he keeps wrath for his enemies.
3 Yahweh is patient and mighty,
but he never lets the guilty go unpunished.
He travels in the whirlwind and the tempest,
and the clouds are the dust kicked up by his feet.
4 He rebukes the sea and dries it,
and all the rivers he makes dry.
Bashan languishes, and Carmel,
and the flower of Lebanon fades.
5 The mountains quake because of him,
and the hills melt away.
The earth heaves at his presence,
the world and all who dwell in it.
6 Who can stand before his indignation?
And who can rise up in the heat of his anger?
His wrath is poured out like fire,
and the rocks are torn apart by him.
7 Yahweh is kind,
a refuge when trouble comes;
he cares for those who shelter in him.
8 But with an overflowing flood
he will make a full end of her place,[c]
and darkness shall pursue his enemies.

9 What do you devise against Yahweh?
He will make a full end;
distress shall not rise up a second time.
10 For though they are tangled like thorns
and drunk as with their drink,
they shall be devoured like stubble fully dried.[d]
11 From you has gone out one
who devises evil against Yahweh,
a counselor of worthlessness.[e]
12 Thus says Yahweh:
"Though they are at full strength and many as well,
even so they shall be cut down and pass away.
Though I have afflicted you,
I will afflict you no more.
13 And now I will break his yoke from off you,
and I will tear your bonds apart."
14 And Yahweh has given command concerning you:
"No more of your name shall be sown;
out of the house of your gods I will cut off
the graven image and the molten image.
I will prepare your grave, for you are vile."
15 Behold, upon the mountains the feet of him who brings good news,
who proclaims peace![f]
Celebrate your feasts, O Judah;
pay your vows;
for the worthless one shall not again pass through you;
he is cut off completely.

Notes

- a (1:1) "Oracle": Hebrew massa', which can also mean "burden." The name Nahum means "comfort" or "comforter." Where Elkosh was is not known.
- b (1:2) Hebrew El qanno'. The poem in verses 2–8 seems partly to follow the order of the Hebrew alphabet (an acrostic), though the pattern is incomplete. In the next line, "a master of wrath" is literally "a lord (ba'al) of wrath," meaning one full of wrath.

- c (1:8) “Her place” refers to Nineveh. The Septuagint has “those that rise up against him,” reading the Hebrew letters differently. The next line can also be translated “and he will pursue his enemies into darkness.”
- d (1:10) The Hebrew of this verse is obscure, and the translation is uncertain.
- e (1:11) Hebrew beliyya‘al, “worthlessness, wickedness.” The same word is translated “the worthless one” in verse 15.
- f (1:15) Compare Isaiah 52:7, which Romans 10:15 quotes. In Hebrew this verse is 2:1, so English 2:1–13 is Hebrew 2:2–14.

Chapter 2

1 One who scatters has come up against your face.[a]
Guard the rampart;
watch the road;
brace your loins;
gather all your strength.
2 For Yahweh is restoring the majesty of Jacob
like the majesty of Israel,
for the emptiers have emptied them out
and destroyed their vine branches.
3 The shield of his mighty men is made red;
the warriors are clothed in scarlet;
the chariots gleam with the fire of steel
on the day he prepares for battle,
and the spears of cypress are brandished.[b]
4 The chariots rage in the streets;
they rush to and fro in the squares;
their appearance is like torches;
they dart about like the lightning.
5 He calls to mind his nobles;
they stumble as they march;
they hurry to her wall,
and the siege shield is set up.
6 The gates of the rivers are opened,
and the palace melts away.

7 It is decided: she is stripped; she is carried off,[c]
and her maidservants moan like the sound of doves,
beating upon their breasts.
8 Nineveh has been like a pool of water all her days,[d]
and now they flee.
"Stand! Stand!" they cry,
but no one turns back.
9 Take the spoil of silver, take the spoil of gold!
For the store has no end,
wealth of every precious thing.
10 Emptiness, desolation, and ruin!
Hearts melt and knees give way;
anguish is in all loins,
and all their faces grow pale.
11 Where now is that lions' lair,
the place where young lions fed,
where lion and lioness walked,
and cubs played unafraid?
12 The lion ripped up plenty for his young
and choked the kill for his mates;
he stocked his caves with victims
and his lairs with mangled meat.
13 "I am your enemy," announces Yahweh of Armies,[e]
"and I will set your chariots ablaze,[f]
the sword will eat up your young lions,
I will remove your prey from the land,
and the cry of your envoys will never again be heard."

Notes

- a (2:1) Hebrew 2:2. "One who scatters" can also be translated "a shatterer." The Septuagint differs: "one who has been delivered from affliction has come up panting into your presence."
- b (2:3) Literally "and the cypresses are made to quiver." The Septuagint has "and the horsemen shall be thrown into confusion," reading parashim ("horsemen") for beroshim ("cypresses"). The Hebrew word translated "steel" (peladot) is rare, and its meaning is uncertain; some take it to mean "torches."

- c (2:7) The Hebrew word translated “It is decided” (hutstsav) is obscure. Some older translations treat it as a name (“Huzzab”); others take it to mean the queen or a goddess’s image.
- d (2:8) The Hebrew phrase translated “all her days” is difficult. The Septuagint has “her waters shall be as a pool of water.”
- e (2:13) Hebrew YHWH Tseva’ot, traditionally “the LORD of hosts.” The “armies” are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel. The title is given as “Yahweh of Armies” throughout. In Hebrew this verse is 2:14.
- f (2:13) Hebrew “her chariots.” The Septuagint has “your multitude.”

Chapter 3

1 Woe to the city of blood,
all of it full of lies and plunder;
the prey never departs!
2 The crack of the whip and the rumble of the wheel,
the galloping horse and the bounding chariot!
3 Horsemen charging, the flashing sword and the glittering spear,
a multitude of slain, a mass of corpses,
dead bodies without end;
they stumble over their dead.
4 All for the countless harlotries of the harlot,
graceful and charming, a mistress of sorceries,
who sells nations by her harlotries
and peoples by her sorceries.
5 “I am your enemy,” announces Yahweh of Armies,
“and I will pull your skirts up over your face,
show the nations your nakedness
and the kingdoms your disgrace.
6 I will cast filth upon you
and disgrace you,
and set you up as a gazingstock.
7 And it shall come to pass that all who look on you shall shrink from you and say,
‘Nineveh is laid waste; who will grieve for her?’
Where shall I seek comforters for you?”[a]

8 Are you better than No-amon,[b]
that sat by the Nile channels,
with water all around her,
whose rampart was the sea,
and water her wall?[c]
9 Cush was her strength, and Egypt, without limit;
Put and the Libyans were your helpers.[d]
10 Yet she too went into exile;
she went into captivity;
her little ones also were dashed to pieces
at the head of every street;
they cast lots for her honored men,
and all her great men were bound in chains.
11 You also shall be drunk;
you shall go into hiding;
you also shall seek a refuge from the enemy.
12 All your strongholds are fig trees with the firstfruits:
if they are shaken,
they fall into the mouth of the eater.
13 Behold, your troops in your midst are women.
The gates of your land are thrown wide open to your enemies;
fire has devoured your bars.
14 Draw water for the siege;
strengthen your fortresses;
go into the clay and tread the mortar;
take hold of the brick mold!
15 There the fire shall devour you;
the sword shall cut you off;
it shall devour you as the young locust devours.
Multiply yourself like the young locust;
multiply yourself like the locust swarm![e]
16 You have multiplied your merchants
more than the stars of the heavens;
the young locust strips and flies away.

17 Your guardsmen are like the locust swarm,
and your officials like clouds of grasshoppers
that settle in the walls on a cold day;
when the sun rises, they flee,
and no one knows the place where they are.[f]
18 Your shepherds slumber, O king of Assyria;
your nobles lie still.
Your people are scattered on the mountains,
with no one to gather them.
19 Nothing can ease your injury;
your wound is fatal.
Everyone who learns of you
applauds your fall.
For who has escaped your endless cruelty?

Notes

- a (3:7) "Comforters" (menahamim) plays on the name Nahum ("comfort").
- b (3:8) No-amon, "city of Amon," is Thebes in Upper Egypt. The Assyrians sacked it about 663 BC.
- c (3:8) Here "the sea" (yam) means the broad waters of the Nile. "And water her wall" is literally "from the sea her wall." The Septuagint has "and whose walls are water."
- d (3:9) Cush is the upper Nile region (ancient Nubia). Put was probably in Libya, though some place it on the African coast of the Red Sea. The Hebrew has "your helpers," but the Septuagint has "her helpers."
- e (3:15) The Hebrew uses several words for locusts (yeleq, 'arbeh, and gov in verse 17). The kinds or stages of locust they refer to are uncertain.
- f (3:17) The words translated "guardsmen" (minzarim) and "officials" (tifsarim) are rare. The second may be a loanword from Akkadian, and the precise meaning of both is uncertain.

Habakkuk

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The oracle that Habakkuk the prophet saw.[a]
2 Yahweh, how long must I plead for help
while you refuse to listen?
I shout to you, “Violence!”
yet you do not rescue.
3 Why do you make me see iniquity,
and why do you look upon trouble?
Ruin and violence are before me;
there is strife, and contention arises.
4 So the law grows numb,
and justice never goes forth;
for the wicked hem in the righteous;
so justice goes forth twisted.
5 “Look among the nations, and see;[b]
be astonished and amazed!
For I am doing a work in your days
that you would not believe if it were told.
6 For behold, I am raising up the Chaldeans,[c]
that bitter and impetuous nation,
which marches through the breadth of the earth
to seize dwellings that are not its own.
7 It is dreadful and fearsome;
its justice and its dignity go forth from itself.
8 Its horses are swifter than leopards,
and keener than wolves at evening.
Its horsemen gallop proudly;
its horsemen come from far away;
they fly like an eagle swooping to devour.

9 They all come for violence;
the set of their faces is forward;[d]
they gather captives like sand.
10 At kings they scoff,
and rulers are a laughingstock to them.
They laugh at every fortress,
for they heap up earth and capture it.
11 Then they sweep on like the wind and pass by,
and become guilty, they whose own strength is their god."[e]
12 Are you not eternal,
Yahweh my God, my Holy One?
We will not perish.[f]
Yahweh, you have set them in place to punish us;
Rock, you have established them to correct us.
13 Your eyes are too pure to look upon evil,
and you cannot gaze upon wrong.
Why then do you look on the treacherous[g]
and keep silent when the wicked swallows up
one more righteous than he?
14 You make mankind like the fish of the sea,
like creeping things that have no ruler.
15 He lifts them all up with the angle;
he hauls them away in his net
and gathers them in his dragnet;
therefore he rejoices and exults.
16 Therefore he sacrifices to his net
and burns incense to his dragnet;
for by them his portion is rich
and his food is plentiful.
17 Shall he therefore keep emptying his net,[h]
and slaying nations continually without pity?

Notes

- a (1:1) "Oracle": Hebrew massa', which can also mean "burden." The meaning of the name Habakkuk is uncertain. It may come from a Hebrew root meaning "embrace," or it may be related to the Akkadian name of a garden plant (hambaququ).

- b (1:5) The Septuagint has “Behold, you despisers,” apparently reading bogedim (“traitors, the treacherous”) for baggoyim (“among the nations”). Acts 13:41 quotes the verse in that form. The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran (1QpHab) quotes the line as “among the nations,” as the Masoretic Text has it. Its commentary, however, applies the passage to “the traitors.”
- c (1:6) The Chaldeans were the Neo-Babylonian dynasty and its people. They overthrew Assyria and conquered Judah, taking Jerusalem in 597 and 586 BC.
- d (1:9) The Hebrew phrase translated “the set of their faces” is obscure.
- e (1:11) Literally “and he shall be guilty, he whose strength is his god.” The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran reads “and he makes his strength his god” (wayyasem instead of we’ashem).
- f (1:12) According to an ancient Jewish tradition, this is one of the places where the scribes altered the wording out of reverence, and the original was “You shall not die.” The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran and the Septuagint both read “we.”
- g (1:13) The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran has a plural, “Why do you look on, you treacherous ones?”
- h (1:17) The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran reads “Therefore he keeps drawing his sword” (harbo, instead of hermo, “his net”).

Chapter 2

1 Upon my watch I will stand,
and set myself upon the tower;
I will look out to see what he will speak with me,
and what reply I shall make to my complaint.[a]
2 And Yahweh answered me and said:
“Write the vision;
make it plain upon tablets,
so that one may run who reads it.[b]
3 For the vision is still for the appointed time;
it hastens toward the end, and it will not lie.
If it seems slow, wait for it;
for it will surely come; it will not delay.[c]
4 “Behold, the one who is puffed up,
his soul is not upright within him;
but the righteous shall live by his faithfulness.[d]
5 “Wine, moreover, is a traitor;[e]
the proud man never rests at home.
His appetite gapes wide as Sheol,[f]

and like death he is never full.
He rakes in every nation
and gathers up all peoples."
6 Shall not all these take up a taunt against him,
with mocking riddles about him, and say,
"Woe to him who multiplies what does not belong to him—
how long?—
and makes himself heavy with pledges!"
7 Shall not those who bite you rise up in a moment,
and those wake who shake you violently?
And you shall become plunder to them.
8 Because you plundered so many nations,
the rest of the peoples will plunder you,
for human bloodshed and violence to the land,
to cities and everyone who lives in them.
9 Woe to him who gets evil gain for his house,
to set his nest on high,
to be delivered from the grasp of evil!
10 You have devised shame for your house
by cutting off many peoples;
you have sinned against your own soul.
11 For out of the wall the stone shall cry,
and out of the timber the rafter shall answer it.
12 Doom to the man who constructs a town by murder
and establishes a city on injustice!
13 Behold, is it not from Yahweh of Armies[g]
that peoples toil only for the fire,
and nations weary themselves for nothing?
14 For the earth shall be filled
with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh,
as the waters cover the sea.[h]
15 Woe to him who makes his neighbors drink,
pouring out your wrath and making them drunk,
in order to look upon their nakedness![i]

16 You will be sated with shame instead of glory.
Drink, you also, and be exposed as uncircumcised![j]
The cup in Yahweh's right hand will come around to you,
and utter disgrace will be upon your glory.
17 The violence you did to Lebanon will overwhelm you,
and the slaughter of its animals will terrify you,[k]
for human bloodshed and violence to the land,
to cities and everyone who lives in them.
18 What profit is an idol
when its maker has carved it,
a molten image and a teacher of falsehood,
that the one who shapes it should trust in what he has shaped,
making idols that cannot speak?
19 Woe to him who says to a piece of wood, "Wake up!"
or to a mute stone, "Arise!"
Can this teach?
Behold, it is plated with gold and silver,
and there is no breath at all within it.
20 But Yahweh is in his holy temple;
let all the earth keep silence before him.

Notes

- a (2:1) Or "concerning my reproof."
- b (2:2) Or "so that a herald may run with it."
- c (2:3) Hebrews 10:37 quotes verses 3–4 in their Septuagint form. Compare "the end" here with 2 Peter 3:9.
- d (2:4) Or "by his faith." Hebrew be'emunato: 'emunah is steadfastness, faithfulness, and trust. The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran quotes the line as it stands in the Masoretic Text, and its commentary applies it to those whom God will deliver "because of their toil and their faith in the Teacher of Righteousness." The Septuagint reads "by my faith" (or "by my faithfulness," meaning God's). Some Septuagint manuscripts read "my righteous one shall live by faith," the form that Hebrews 10:38 follows. The Greek Minor Prophets Scroll from Nahal Hever is reported to read "by his faith," agreeing with the Hebrew. Paul quotes the line, without a pronoun, in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11.
- e (2:5) The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran reads "wealth (hon) is treacherous" instead of "wine (hayyayin)." The Septuagint has "the arrogant man and the scorner."

- f (2:5) Sheol is the realm of the dead, the grave.
- g (2:13) Compare Isaiah 11:9.
- h (2:14) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." The "armies" are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel.
- i (2:15) The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran reads "to look upon their festivals" (mo'adehem instead of me'orehem, "their nakedness"). Its commentary applies the verse to an attack by "the Wicked Priest" on the Teacher of Righteousness on the Day of Atonement.
- j (2:16) The Hebrew he'arel means "show your foreskin, be exposed as uncircumcised." The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran reads hera'el, "and stagger," with two letters reversed. The Septuagint ("shake… and quake") and other ancient versions point the same way, and many translations follow that reading.
- k (2:17) "Will terrify you" follows the Septuagint. The Masoretic Text has a form usually read as "will terrify them," and the Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran has another spelling of the word.

Chapter 3

1 A prayer of Habakkuk the prophet, according to Shigionoth.[a]
2 Yahweh, I have heard of your fame,
and I am awestruck.
Yahweh, renew your deeds in our own time;
make them known in these years;
in your anger, remember compassion.[b]
3 God came from Teman,
the Holy One from Mount Paran. Selah[c]
His glory blanketed the skies,
and the earth overflowed with his praise.
4 His shining was as the light of day;
rays came forth from his hand,[d]
and there was the hiding of his power.
5 Pestilence went before his face,
and plague went out at his feet.[e]
6 He stood and measured the earth;[f]
he looked and made the nations tremble.
The everlasting mountains were shattered;
the ancient hills sank low.
His goings are as of old.

7 Under affliction I saw the tents of Cushan;[g]
the curtains of Midian's land were shaking.
8 Was Yahweh angry with the rivers?
Was your anger against the rivers,
or your fury against the sea,
when you rode upon your horses,
your chariots of salvation?
9 Your bow was laid bare;
the arrows were sworn by your word.[h] Selah
You split the earth with rivers.
10 The mountains saw you and writhed;
the torrent of waters swept by;[i]
the deep uttered its voice
and raised its hands on high.
11 Sun and moon stood still in their dwelling
at the light of your arrows as they flew,
at the gleam of your flashing spear.
12 In fury you strode over the earth;
in wrath you threshed the nations.
13 You went forth for the salvation of your people,
for the salvation of your anointed.
You crushed the head of the house of the wicked,
laying bare the foundation to the neck. Selah
14 With his own spears you stabbed the heads of his warriors,[j]
who rushed out like a storm to scatter me,
gloating as though devouring the helpless in hiding.
15 You trampled the sea with your horses,
the heaving of many waters.
16 I heard, and my body trembled;
my lips quivered at the sound;
rottenness entered into my bones;
I trembled where I stood,
because I must wait quietly for the day of distress
to come upon the people who invade us.

17 Though the fig tree does not blossom,
and no grapes grow on the vines;
though the olive harvest fails,
and the fields yield no grain;
though the sheep vanish from the pen,
and no cattle stand in the barns,
18 yet I will rejoice in Yahweh;
I will exult in the God of my salvation.
19 Yahweh, the Lord, is my strength;[k]
he makes my feet like the feet of deer,
and makes me tread upon my high places.
For the choir director: on my stringed instruments.[l]

Notes

- a (3:1) Shigionoth is probably a musical or liturgical term. Its meaning is unknown; compare the title of Psalm 7. The Habakkuk Commentary from Qumran comments only on chapters 1–2.
- b (3:2) The Septuagint has a very different text here, beginning "You shall be known between the two living creatures."
- c (3:3) Teman (in Edom) and Mount Paran (in the Sinai peninsula) lie to the south of Judah. Compare Deuteronomy 33:2 and Judges 5:4. Selah is a term of uncertain meaning, probably musical or liturgical; it occurs here and in verses 9 and 13.
- d (3:4) Hebrew qarnayim, literally "horns," used here of rays of light.
- e (3:5) Hebrew dever ("pestilence") and reshef ("plague, burning fever"). Reshef is also the name of a Canaanite god of plague, and here it may picture plague as one of God's attendants.
- f (3:6) Or "and shook the earth."
- g (3:7) Cushan appears only here. It may be a poetic name for Cush, or the name of a tribe connected with Midian (compare Numbers 12:1).
- h (3:9) The Hebrew of this line is notoriously obscure. Literally it is "sworn were the rods (or tribes) of the word."
- i (3:10) The Wadi Murabba'at Minor Prophets scroll reads "the clouds poured out water," as in Psalm 77:17. The Masoretic Text has "the torrent of waters swept by."
- j (3:14) The Hebrew of verse 14 is difficult, and the translation is uncertain.
- k (3:19) Hebrew YHWH Adonai. "My high places" are the heights.
- l (3:19) This note is addressed to the leader of the temple music, like the titles of many psalms.

Zephaniah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 The word of Yahweh that came to Zephaniah the son of Cushi, the
son of Gedaliah, the son of Amariah, the son of Hezekiah, in the days
of Josiah the son of Amon, king of Judah.[a]
2 "I will utterly sweep away everything
from upon the face of the ground," declares Yahweh.
3 "I will remove people and livestock;
I will remove the birds that fly in the sky
and the fish of the ocean,
and the idols[b] along with the wicked.
I will eliminate humanity
from the face of the earth," declares Yahweh.
4 "I will raise my hand against Judah
and all who live in Jerusalem;
from this place I will eliminate every trace of Baal,
the names of the pagan priests along with the temple priests,[c]
5 those who worship the stars of heaven
from their rooftops;
those who kneel and swear loyalty to Yahweh
while also swearing by Milcom;[d]
6 those who have turned back from following Yahweh,
who have not sought Yahweh nor inquired of him."
7 Hush in the presence of the Lord Yahweh!
The day of Yahweh is close;
Yahweh has made ready a slaughter
and set apart those he has invited.
8 "And it shall come to pass on the day of Yahweh's sacrifice
that I will punish the princes and the sons of the king,
and all who are clothed in foreign clothing.

9 On that day I will punish
all who leap across the threshold,[e]
and those who load their lords' houses
with violent loot and lies.
10 "On that day," declares Yahweh,
"there shall be the sound of a cry from the Fish Gate,
a wail from the Second Quarter,[f]
and a great crash from the hills.
11 Howl, you who dwell in the Mortar![g]
For all the people of Canaan are brought to silence;
all who weigh out silver are cut off.
12 At that time I will search Jerusalem with lamps,
and I will punish the men
who are thickening on their dregs,[h]
who say in their heart,
'Yahweh will not do good,
nor will he do evil.'
13 Their wealth shall become plunder
and their houses a waste.
Though they build houses, they shall not dwell in them;
though they plant vineyards, they shall not drink their wine."
14 The great day of Yahweh is near,
it is near and hurries greatly.
Hark, the day of Yahweh! It is bitter;
the mighty man cries aloud there.
15 That day will be a day of rage,[i]
a time of anguish and misery,
a time of wreckage and waste,
a time of darkness and dimness,
a time of storm clouds and blackness,
16 a day of the ram's horn and of the war cry
against the walled cities
and against the high corner towers.
17 "I will bring distress upon mankind,
and they shall walk like the blind,

because they have sinned against Yahweh;
their blood shall be poured out like dust,
and their flesh like dung."
18 Neither their silver nor their gold
will have power to save them
on the day of Yahweh's fury.
His blazing jealousy will consume
the whole earth,
for he will bring a sudden, terrifying end
to everyone living on the planet.

Notes

- a (1:1) Zephaniah means "Yahweh has hidden" or "Yahweh has treasured up"; Cushi means "Cushite"; Gedaliah, "Yahweh is great"; Amariah, "Yahweh has spoken"; and Hezekiah, "Yahweh strengthens." This Hezekiah may be the king of that name (reigned about 715–686 BC), though the text does not say so. Josiah reigned about 640–609 BC.
- b (1:3) The Hebrew phrase "and the stumbling blocks" (perhaps meaning idols) is obscure, and the Septuagint lacks it.
- c (1:4) Hebrew kemarim, a word used for priests of foreign gods (compare 2 Kings 23:5 and Hosea 10:5). The Septuagint has "the names of the priests."
- d (1:5) Malcam means "their king." It probably refers to Milcom, the god of the Ammonites (1 Kings 11:5), and some ancient versions read "Milcom." The Septuagint has "their king."
- e (1:9) This may refer to a pagan custom (compare 1 Samuel 5:5), or to palace servants rushing in to seize the goods of others.
- f (1:10) The Fish Gate and the Second Quarter (Hebrew Mishneh) were in the northern part of Jerusalem.
- g (1:11) Hebrew Makhtesh, "mortar" or "hollow," probably a district of Jerusalem. "The people of Canaan" may also be translated "the merchants."
- h (1:12) That is, like wine left too long on its sediment: complacent and stagnant (compare Jeremiah 48:11).
- i (1:15) In the Latin Vulgate, the opening words of this verse are Dies irae, dies illa ("A day of wrath, that day"). They gave the medieval hymn Dies irae its name.

Chapter 2

1 Gather yourselves together and gather,[a]
O nation without shame,
2 before the decree brings forth—
like chaff the day passes by—

before the fierce anger of Yahweh
comes upon you,
before there comes upon you
the day of the anger of Yahweh.
3 Seek Yahweh, all you humble of the land,
who do his justice;
seek righteousness; seek humility;
perhaps you will be hidden
on the day of the anger of Yahweh.[b]
4 For Gaza shall be forsaken,
and Ashkelon a desolation;
Ashdod they shall drive out at noon,
and Ekron shall be uprooted.[c]
5 Disaster for those living along the coast,
you nation of Cretans![d]
Yahweh's message is aimed at you,
Canaan, land of the Philistines:
I will wipe you out, leaving no one living there.
6 And the land by the sea shall become pastures,
caves for shepherds, and pens for sheep.[e]
7 The coast shall belong to the remnant of the house of Judah;
on it they shall graze;
in the houses of Ashkelon
they shall lie down at evening.
For Yahweh their God will visit them
and restore their fortunes.
8 "I have listened to Moab's insults
and the abuse of the Ammonites,
who have mocked my people
and boasted over their borders.
9 Therefore, as surely as I live," announces Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel,[f]
"Moab will end up like Sodom,
and Ammon like Gomorrah,
overgrown with weeds, pits of salt,

and permanent ruin.
The rest of my people will loot them;
those of my nation who are left will take their land."
10 This is what they get for their arrogance,
for scorning and boasting
against the people of Yahweh of Armies.
11 Yahweh will terrify them,
for he will wither all the earth's gods;[g]
and every distant shore of the nations
will worship him, each in its own place.
12 You also, O Cushites,[h]
shall be slain by my sword.
13 And he will stretch out his hand against the north
and destroy Assyria,
and he will make Nineveh a desolation,
dry as the wilderness.
14 Flocks will bed down in her center,
every kind of creature;[i]
the desert owl and the porcupine
will roost on her capitals;
hooting will sound from the windows,
rubble will fill the doorways,
because he has stripped her cedar paneling bare.
15 This is the exultant city
that dwelt securely,
that said in her heart,
"I am, and there is none else."
How she has become a desolation,
a lair for wild beasts!
Everyone who passes by her
hisses and shakes his fist.

Notes

- a (2:1) The Hebrew of verses 1–2 is difficult. The verb in verse 1 may mean "gather like stubble," and the phrase translated "before the decree takes effect" is literally "before the decree gives birth."

- b (2:3) "Hidden" (Hebrew sathar) may echo the name Zephaniah ("Yahweh has hidden"), though the verb is different.
- c (2:4) The verse plays on the Hebrew names: Gaza (ʻAzzah) will be forsaken (ʻazuvah), and Ekron (ʻEqron) will be uprooted (teʻaqer).
- d (2:5) The Cherethites were a people of the coast, closely linked with the Philistines and probably from Crete (Kaphtor).
- e (2:6) The Hebrew word translated "meadows" (keroth) is uncertain. It may refer to wells or to shepherds' huts, and it may echo "Cherethites" in verse 5.
- f (2:9) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." The "armies" are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel. The title is translated "Yahweh of Armies" throughout.
- g (2:11) Or "he will make lean," that is, cut off the offerings by which the gods were thought to be fed.
- h (2:12) Cush is the upper Nile region (ancient Nubia). Egypt was ruled by a Cushite dynasty until 656 BC.
- i (2:14) "Nation" may refer to any kind of creature ("every kind of beast"). The birds and animals named in this verse cannot be identified with certainty. The Septuagint differs in several places, for example "ravens in her porches."

Chapter 3

1 Woe to her who is rebellious and defiled,
the oppressing city![a]
2 She has not obeyed his call;
she has refused discipline.
She has not put her trust in Yahweh;
she has not come close to her God.
3 Her officials within her are roaring lions;
her judges are wolves of the evening
that leave nothing until the morning.
4 Her prophets are reckless,
men of treachery;
her priests have profaned what is holy;
they have done violence to the law.
5 Yahweh within her is righteous;
he does no injustice;
morning by morning he brings his justice to light;
he does not fail;
but the unjust knows no shame.

6 “I have destroyed nations;
their watchtowers lie in ruins;
I have emptied their streets
so that nobody walks there;
their cities are devastated,
with no people, no inhabitants.
7 I said, ‘Surely you will fear me;
you will accept correction.’
Then her dwelling would not be cut off,
for all that I appointed against her.
But they rose early and made all their deeds corrupt.
8 “Therefore wait for me,” declares Yahweh,
“until the day that I rise up for the prey.[b]
For my judgment is to gather the nations,
that I may assemble the kingdoms,
to pour my indignation on them,
even all my fierce anger;
for all the earth shall be devoured
by the fire of my zeal.
9 “For then I will turn to the peoples a purified lip,[c]
that they may all call upon Yahweh’s name
and serve him with one shoulder.[d]
10 From beyond the rivers of Cush
my worshipers, the daughter of my scattered ones,
shall bring my offering.[e]
11 In that day you will not be ashamed
for any of your doings
in which you transgressed against me;
for then I will take away from among you
those who exult in their pride,
and you shall no longer be haughty
on my holy mountain.
12 Instead I will leave among you
a poor and humble people,
who will find shelter in Yahweh’s name.

13 The remnant of Israel shall do no injustice
and speak no lies,
nor shall a deceitful tongue be found in their mouth;
for they shall graze and lie down,
and none shall make them afraid."
14 Shout for joy, daughter of Zion;
sing out, Israel!
Rejoice and celebrate with your whole heart,
daughter of Jerusalem!
15 Yahweh has removed your judgments;
he has turned back your enemy.
The King of Israel, Yahweh, is in your midst;
you shall never again fear evil.
16 On that day Jerusalem will be told:
"Zion, do not be afraid;
do not let your hands go limp.
17 Yahweh your God lives among you,
a warrior who gives victory;
he will take delight in you,
renew you by his love,[f]
and celebrate over you with songs."
18 "I will gather those who grieve for the appointed feasts;
they were from you,
a burden of reproach upon her.[g]
19 Behold, at that time I will deal with all who afflict you,
and I will rescue the limping
and gather those who were driven away,
and I will make them a praise and a name
in every land where they were put to shame.[h]
20 At that time I will lead you home,
and at that time I will assemble you;
I will make you famous and honored
among every people on earth,
when I reverse your misfortunes before your very eyes," says Yahweh.

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew mor'ah, "rebellious," may play on mar'ah, "seen," or on Moriah, the temple mount. The city is Jerusalem.
- b (3:8) Hebrew la'ad, "for the prey." The Septuagint has "for a witness," reading the same letters as le'ed.
- c (3:9) Literally "I will turn to the peoples a pure lip." The Wadi Murabba'at Minor Prophets scroll reads "upon the peoples."
- d (3:9) That is, "side by side, with one accord."
- e (3:10) The Hebrew of the second line is difficult. Some take "the daughter of Putsai" as a place name. The Septuagint has "I will receive my dispersed ones; they shall offer sacrifices to me."
- f (3:17) Literally "he will be silent in his love," perhaps meaning that he will no longer speak of their sins. The Septuagint has "and shall renew you in his love," reading yehaddesh for yaharish.
- g (3:18) The Hebrew of this verse is obscure, and the translation is uncertain. The Septuagint has "And I will gather your afflicted ones. Alas! who has taken up a reproach against her?"
- h (3:19) Literally "in all the earth, their shame."

Haggai

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 On the first day of the sixth month of King Darius's second year
(in August–September),[a] a message from Yahweh came through the
prophet Haggai[b] for Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel, who governed
Judah, and for the high priest Joshua son of Jehozadak:[c] 2 "Thus says
Yahweh of Armies:[d] This people says, 'The time has not come, the
time for the house of Yahweh to be rebuilt.'"
3 Then Yahweh's message came through the prophet Haggai: 4 "Is it a
time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, while this
house lies in ruins?[e] 5 Now therefore, thus says Yahweh of Armies: Set
your heart on your ways. 6 You have sown much and brought in little;
you eat, but never to fullness; you drink, but never to drunkenness;
you clothe yourselves, but no one is warm. And he who earns wages
earns them for a bag pierced with holes.
7 "Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Set your heart on your ways. 8 Go up
into the hills, bring timber, and rebuild the house, so I can enjoy it
and be honored there, says Yahweh. 9 You expected a large harvest,
but it turned out small; whatever you brought home, I blew away.
Why? announces Yahweh of Armies. Because my house remains a
ruin, while every one of you hurries off to his own house. 10 Therefore
over you the heavens have held back the dew, and the earth has held
back its produce. 11 I have summoned a drought[f] over the land and the
hills, over the grain, the new wine, the oil, whatever the soil produces,
over people and livestock, and over everything they work for."
12 Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Joshua the son of
Jehozadak, the high priest, with all the remnant of the people, obeyed
the voice of Yahweh their God and the words of Haggai the prophet,
as Yahweh their God had sent him. And the people feared before Yah-
weh. 13 Then Haggai, the messenger of Yahweh, spoke to the people

with Yahweh's message,[g] saying, "I am with you, declares Yahweh." 14 And Yahweh stirred up the spirit of Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and the spirit of Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest, and the spirit of all the remnant of the people. And they came and did work on the house of Yahweh of Armies, their God, 15 on the twenty-fourth day of the month, in the sixth month (in August–September), in the second year of Darius the king.[h]

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew "in the sixth month," that is, Elul, in the calendar whose year begins in the spring. The second year of Darius I (who reigned 522–486 BC) is 520 BC. As the dates are commonly reckoned, this day was about August 29, 520 BC. Because the Hebrew months were lunar, each corresponds to parts of two modern months.
- b (1:1) Haggai probably means "festal" (from hag, "feast"). The Septuagint has "Speak to Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, of the tribe of Judah."
- c (1:1) Zerubbabel probably means "seed of Babylon"; Shealtiel, "I have asked God"; Joshua, "Yahweh saves" (in Greek, Iēsous, "Jesus"); Jehozadak, "Yahweh is righteous." Joshua is called Jeshua in Ezra and Nehemiah.
- d (1:2) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." The "armies" are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel. The title is translated "Yahweh of Armies" throughout.
- e (1:4) Hebrew harev, "in ruins." The same word appears in verse 9.
- f (1:11) Hebrew horev, "drought," plays on harev, "in ruins" (verses 4 and 9): because the house lies in ruins (harev), Yahweh calls a drought (horev).
- g (1:13) Or "with Yahweh's commission." The word "messenger" (mal'akh) is the same word as in Malachi ("my messenger").
- h (1:15) About September 21, 520 BC. Some scholars attach the date to the beginning of 2:1.

Chapter 2

1 On the twenty-first day of the seventh month (in September–October),[a] Yahweh's message came through the prophet Haggai:[b] 2 "Speak now to Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and to Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest, and to the remnant of the people, saying, 3 'Who is left among you who saw this house in its former glory? And how do you see it now? Is it not as nothing in your eyes? 4 Yet now be strong, O Zerubbabel, declares Yahweh. Be strong, O Joshua son of Jehozadak, the high priest. Be strong, all you people of the land, declares Yahweh. Work, for I am with you,

declares Yahweh of Armies, 5 This is the promise I made you when
you left Egypt.[c] My Spirit remains among you. Do not be afraid.
6 "'For thus says Yahweh of Armies: Yet once more, in a little while, I
will shake the heavens and the earth and the sea and the dry land.[d] 7
And I will make all nations tremble, and the desirable things of every
nation shall come,[e] and I will fill this house with glory, says Yahweh
of Armies. 8 The silver is mine, and the gold is mine, declares Yahweh
of Armies. 9 The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the
former, says Yahweh of Armies. And in this place I will give peace,
declares Yahweh of Armies.'"[f]
10 On the twenty-fourth day of the ninth month (in November–
December) of Darius's second year,[g] Yahweh's message came to the
prophet Haggai: 11 "Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Ask the priests for
a ruling:[h] 12 'If a man carries holy meat in the fold of his garment, and
with his fold touches bread or pottage or wine or oil or any food, will
it be made holy?'" And the priests answered, "No." 13 Then Haggai
said, "If someone defiled by a corpse touches any of these, will it be
defiled?" And the priests answered, "It will be defiled." 14 Then Haggai
answered and said, "So is this people, and so is this nation before me,
declares Yahweh, and so is every work of their hands; and what they
offer there is unclean.[i]
15 "And now, set your heart on it from this day onward.[j] Before stone
was laid upon stone in the temple of Yahweh, 16 how did you fare?
When one came to a heap of twenty measures, there were but ten;
when one came to the wine vat to draw fifty measures, there were
but twenty.[k] 17 I struck you with blight and with mildew and with hail
in all the work of your hands, yet you did not turn to me,[l] declares
Yahweh. 18 Set your heart from this day onward, from the twenty-
fourth day of the ninth month (in November–December), from the
day that the foundation of the temple of Yahweh was laid—set your
heart on it: 19 Is the seed yet in the barn? As for the vine, the fig tree,
the pomegranate, and the olive tree, they have borne nothing. From
this day on I will bless you."
20 And the word of Yahweh came a second time to Haggai on the
twenty-fourth day of the month, saying, 21 "Tell Zerubbabel, governor

of Judah: I am about to shake the sky and the earth, 22 and I will topple royal thrones and break the power of the foreign kingdoms. I will overturn chariots and their drivers; horses and riders will fall, each killed by his comrade's sword. 23 On that day, declares Yahweh of Armies, I will take you, O Zerubbabel my servant, the son of Shealtiel, declares Yahweh, and I will make you like a signet ring,[m] for I have chosen you, declares Yahweh of Armies."

Notes

- a (2:1) Tishri, the seventh month. The twenty-first day was the last day of the Feast of Booths (Leviticus 23:34–36). As commonly reckoned, it was about October 17, 520 BC.
- b (2:1) The Wadi Murabba'at Minor Prophets scroll reads "came to Haggai."
- c (2:5) The Septuagint lacks the first clause, "according to the word that I covenanted with you when you came out of Egypt."
- d (2:6) Quoted in Hebrews 12:26–27. The Septuagint has "Yet once I will shake the heaven, and the earth."
- e (2:7) Or "the desire of all nations shall come." The Hebrew noun is singular ("desire," "what is desired"), but the verb is plural, which suggests valued things. The Latin Vulgate's "the desired one of all nations will come" gave rise to a messianic reading. The Septuagint has "the choice portions of all the nations."
- f (2:9) The Septuagint adds "even peace of soul for a possession to everyone who builds, to raise up this temple."
- g (2:10) About December 18, 520 BC. Kislev is the ninth month.
- h (2:11) Hebrew torah, "instruction" or "law."
- i (2:14) The Septuagint adds "and whoever approaches them shall be defiled because of their early burdens; they shall be pained because of their toils; and you have hated him who reproved in the gates" (compare Amos 5:10).
- j (2:15) Hebrew "upward," meaning either "from this day forward" or "backward from this day." The same expression appears in verse 18.
- k (2:16) The measures are not named in the Hebrew. The Septuagint has "twenty measures of barley." In the second clause, the Hebrew "fifty" is literally "fifty of the winepress" (purah).
- l (2:17) Compare Amos 4:9. The Hebrew is literally "yet there was not you to me." The Septuagint has "yet you did not return to me."
- m (2:23) A signet ring was a royal seal, a sign of authority. This reverses the word against Zerubbabel's grandfather Jehoiachin (Coniah) in Jeremiah 22:24.

Zechariah

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the eighth month (October–November) of Darius's second year,[a]
Yahweh's word came to the prophet Zechariah, son of Berechiah,
son of Iddo, saying,[b] 2 "Yahweh was very angry with your fathers.
3 Therefore say to them, Thus says Yahweh of Armies:[c] Return to me,
declares Yahweh of Armies, and I will return to you, says Yahweh of
Armies. 4 Do not be like your ancestors, whom the earlier prophets
called out to: 'This is what Yahweh of Armies says: Turn away at once
from your wicked paths and your wicked actions.' But they would
not listen or give me any notice, says Yahweh. 5 Your fathers—where
are they? And the prophets—do they live forever? 6 But the warnings
and decrees I commissioned my servants the prophets to deliver, did
they not overtake your ancestors? They repented and said, 'Yahweh
of Armies has done to us exactly what he planned for our paths and
actions.'"
7 On the twenty-fourth day of the eleventh month, the month of
Shebat (January–February), in Darius's second year,[d] Yahweh's word
came to the prophet Zechariah, son of Berechiah, son of Iddo, saying,
8 In the night I had a vision: a man riding a red horse, who halted
among the myrtle trees in the glen;[e] behind him were red, chestnut,
and white horses.[f] 9 Then I said, "What are these, my lord?" And the
angel who talked with me said to me, "I will show you what these are."
10 The man standing among the myrtles replied, "These are the ones
Yahweh has sent to patrol the earth." 11 They reported to Yahweh's
angel, who stood among the myrtles, "We have patrolled the earth,
and look, the whole earth is calm and quiet." 12 Then the angel of
Yahweh answered, "O Yahweh of Armies, until when will you with-
hold compassion from Jerusalem and from the cities of Judah, with
which you have been indignant now seventy years?"[g] 13 And Yahweh

answered the angel who talked with me with good words, words of comfort. 14 So the angel who talked with me said to me, "Cry out, saying, 'Thus says Yahweh of Armies: I am jealous for Jerusalem and for Zion with a great jealousy. 15 And with great anger I am angry with the nations at ease; for I was only a little angry, but they furthered the evil. 16 Therefore this is Yahweh's word: I have come back to Jerusalem in mercy; my house will be rebuilt there, declares Yahweh of Armies, and the surveyor's cord will be stretched across Jerusalem.' 17 Proclaim once more: 'This is what Yahweh of Armies says: My towns will again brim with prosperity, and Yahweh will again console Zion and once more select Jerusalem.'"[h]

18 And I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold, four horns![i] 19 And I said to the angel who talked with me, "What are these?" And he said to me, "These are the horns that have scattered Judah, Israel, and Jerusalem." 20 Then Yahweh showed me four craftsmen. 21 I asked, "What have these come to do?" He replied, "These are the horns that dispersed Judah so that nobody could lift up his head. But these craftsmen have come to frighten them and to hurl down the horns of the nations that raised a horn against Judah's land in order to scatter its people."

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew "in the eighth month," that is, Marcheshvan (later Heshvan), in the calendar whose year begins in the spring, in 520 BC. No day is given. Because the Hebrew months were lunar, each corresponds to parts of two modern months.
- b (1:1) Zechariah means "Yahweh remembers"; Berechiah, "Yahweh blesses"; Iddo perhaps "timely." Ezra 5:1 and 6:14 call Zechariah "the son of Iddo," that is, his grandson or descendant. Compare Matthew 23:35.
- c (1:3) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." The "armies" are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel. The title is translated "Yahweh of Armies" throughout.
- d (1:7) Shebat (Shevat) is the eleventh month. As commonly reckoned, this was about February 15, 519 BC.
- e (1:8) Or "in the deep place." The Septuagint has "between the shady mountains" (also in verses 10–11), reading harim, "mountains," for hadassim, "myrtles."
- f (1:8) The color of the second group (Hebrew seruqqim) is uncertain: perhaps "sorrel," "bay," or "speckled." The Septuagint has four colors: "red, and grey, and piebald, and white."
- g (1:12) Compare Jeremiah 25:11–12 and 29:10. From the destruction of the temple in 586 BC to this vision is about seventy years (counted inclusively).

- h (1:17) Hebrew tov, “good,” also “prosperity.”
- i (1:18) English 1:18–21 is Hebrew 2:1–4.

Chapter 2

1 And I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold, a man with a measuring
line in his hand![a] 2 I asked, “Where are you headed?” He told me, “To
measure Jerusalem, to find out its width and its length.” 3 And behold,
the angel who talked with me went out, and another angel went out
to meet him 4 and he said to him, “Run, speak to this young man,
saying, ‘Jerusalem will be settled like unwalled villages, because of
the great number of men and cattle in her midst. 5 And I myself will
be to her a wall of fire all around, declares Yahweh, and I will be the
glory in her midst.’”
6 Up! Up! Flee from the land of the north, declares Yahweh, for I have
spread you out like the four winds of the heavens, declares Yahweh.[b]
7 Up, O Zion! Escape, you who dwell with the daughter of Babylon.
8 For this is what Yahweh of Armies says: after glory he sent me[c]
against the nations that plundered you—for whoever touches you
touches the apple of his eye:[d] 9 “For see, I am swinging my hand over
them, and they shall be spoil to their own servants; and you will know
that Yahweh of Armies has sent me.
10 Sing and rejoice, O daughter of Zion, for behold, I come, and I will
dwell in your midst, declares Yahweh. 11 And many nations shall join
themselves to Yahweh in that day and shall be my people. And I
will dwell in your midst, and you shall know that Yahweh of Armies
has sent me to you. 12 And Yahweh will take possession of Judah as
his portion in the holy land,[e] and will again choose Jerusalem. 13 Be
silent, all flesh, before Yahweh, for he has roused himself from his
holy dwelling.”

Notes

- a (2:1) English 2:1–13 is Hebrew 2:5–17.
- b (2:6) The Septuagint has “for I will gather you from the four winds of heaven.”
- c (2:8) The Hebrew of this phrase is obscure. It may mean “after the glory (that is, the vision) he sent me,” or “with glory he sent me,” or “for his glory’s sake.”

- d (2:8) Hebrew "his eye." Jewish tradition lists this as one of the "corrections of the scribes" (tiqqune sopherim), and it reports that the original reading was "my eye." The word translated "pupil" (bavah) is literally "gate" or "little one" of the eye.
- e (2:12) This is the only place in the Hebrew Bible where the land is called "the holy land."

Chapter 3

1 Then he showed me Joshua the high priest standing before the angel
of Yahweh, and the Accuser[a] standing at his right hand to accuse him.
2 And Yahweh said to the Accuser, "Yahweh rebuke you, O Accuser!
[b] Yahweh who has chosen Jerusalem rebuke you! Is not this a brand
plucked from the fire?" 3 Now Joshua was clothed in filthy garments,
and he was standing before the angel. 4 And he spoke up and said
to those standing in front of him, "Take the filthy clothes off him."
And to him he said, "See, I have made your iniquity pass away from
you, and I will clothe you in fine robes." 5 And I said, "Let them put a
clean turban on his head." So they put a clean turban on his head and
clothed him with garments. And the angel of Yahweh was standing
by.
6 And the angel of Yahweh solemnly charged Joshua, saying, 7 "This
is what Yahweh of Armies says: If you follow my paths and observe
my requirements, then you will govern my house and guard my
courtyards, and I will grant you free passage among these attendants.
8 Listen, Joshua the high priest, you and your colleagues seated before
you, for they are men who serve as a sign: I am about to bring my
servant, the Branch.[c] 9 For behold, the stone that I have set before
Joshua: on one stone are seven eyes.[d] Behold, I will engrave its
inscription, declares Yahweh of Armies, and I will remove the iniquity
of this land in a single day. 10 In that day, declares Yahweh of Armies,
you shall call each man to his neighbor, beneath the vine and beneath
the fig tree."

Notes

- a (3:1) Hebrew hassatan, "the adversary" or "the accuser." With the article, it is a title (compare Job 1–2), not yet a personal name. The verb "to accuse him" (lesitno) comes from the same root. The Septuagint has "the Devil."
- b (3:2) Compare Jude 9. The Septuagint has "The Lord rebuke you, O Devil."

- c (3:8) Hebrew tsemah, “sprout” or “shoot,” a title of the coming king from David’s line (Jeremiah 23:5 and 33:15). See also 6:12.
- d (3:9) Or “seven facets.” The verb translated “engrave” is used for cutting gems; the Septuagint has “I am digging a trench.”

Chapter 4

1 Then the angel who had spoken to me before came back and woke
me, like someone woken from sleep. 2 And he said to me, “What do
you see?” And I said, “I have looked, and there is a lampstand entirely
of gold, and its bowl upon its top, and its seven lamps upon it, seven
and seven pipes for the lamps that are upon its top.[a] 3 And there are
two olive trees by it, one on the right of the bowl and the other on
its left.” 4 And I answered and said to the angel who talked with me,
“What are these, my lord?” 5 Then the angel who talked with me
answered and said to me, “Do you not know what these are?” I said,
“No, my lord.” 6 Then he answered and said to me, “This is the word
of Yahweh to Zerubbabel: Not by might, nor by power, but by my
Spirit, says Yahweh of Armies. 7 What are you, great mountain? In
front of Zerubbabel you will become level ground. He will bring out
the capstone to shouts of ‘Blessing, blessing on it!’”[b]
8 Moreover, the word of Yahweh came to me, saying, 9 “Zerubbabel’s
hands have laid this house’s foundation; his hands will also finish it.
Then you will recognize that Yahweh of Armies sent me to you. 10
For who has despised the day of small things? For these seven shall
rejoice and shall see the plumb stone in the hand of Zerubbabel.[c]
These are the eyes of Yahweh, which range through the whole earth.”
11 Then I answered and said to him, “What are these two olive trees on
the right and the left of the lampstand?” 12 A second time I asked him,
“What are the two olive branches next to the two golden spouts that
empty out the golden oil?”[d] 13 He answered me, “Do you not know
what these things are?” And I said, “No, my lord.” 14 Then he said,
“These are the two sons of oil[e] who stand by the Lord of all the earth.”[f]

Notes

- a (4:2) That is, perhaps seven pipes to each lamp (forty-nine in all), or fourteen in all. The Septuagint has “and seven oil funnels to the lamps.”

- b (4:7) Or “Beauty, beauty to it!” (Hebrew hen hen). The Septuagint differs: “I will bring out the stone of the inheritance, the grace of it the equal of my grace.”
- c (4:10) Hebrew “the stone, the tin” (ha’even habbedil), probably a plumb weight or a separating stone. The Septuagint has “the plummet of tin.” In the Hebrew, “these seven” are the eyes of Yahweh (compare 3:9).
- d (4:12) The Hebrew of this verse is difficult. The word translated “pipes” is unique, and the last phrase is literally “that empty the gold out of themselves.”
- e (4:14) Hebrew bene hayyitshar, “sons of fresh oil,” that is, the anointed ones. They are probably Zerubbabel and Joshua. Compare Revelation 11:4.
- f (4:14) Hebrew adon, “lord,” not the divine title Adonai. This title also appears at 6:5.

Chapter 5

1 Again I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold, a flying scroll![a] 2 And
he said to me, “What do you see?” I answered, “I see a flying scroll. Its
length is thirty feet, and its breadth fifteen feet.”[b] 3 He told me, “This
is the curse sweeping over the surface of the whole land. Everyone
who steals will be removed, as the one side of the scroll declares,
and everyone who swears falsely will be removed, as the other side
declares.[c] 4 I will send it out, declares Yahweh of Armies, and it shall
enter the house of the thief and the house of him who swears falsely
by my name. And it shall lodge in the midst of his house and consume
it, both its timber and its stones.”
5 Then the angel who was speaking with me stepped forward and told
me, “Look up and notice what is appearing.” 6 And I said, “What is
it?” He said, “This is the measuring basket that is going out.”[d] And he
said, “This is their eye in all the land.”[e] 7 And behold, a round cover of
lead was lifted,[f] and this was a woman sitting in the basket! 8 And he
said, “This is Wickedness.” And he cast her down into the middle of
the basket, and cast the lead weight upon its opening. 9 Then I raised
my eyes and looked, and there came out two women, with wind in
their wings; and they had wings like a stork’s wings, and they raised
the basket up between the earth and the heavens. 10 Then I said to the
angel who talked with me, “Where are they taking the basket?” 11 He
said to me, “To build a house for it in the land of Shinar.[g] And when
it is prepared, it will be set down there on its base.”

Notes

- a (5:1) The Septuagint has “a flying sickle,” reading maggal for megillah.
- b (5:2) Hebrew “twenty cubits … ten cubits,” about 9 by 4.5 meters. A cubit is about 18 inches (45 centimeters).
- c (5:3) Or “shall be cleaned out” or “shall go unpunished.” The Hebrew word (niqqah) is ambiguous. Each side of the scroll apparently bore one of the two curses.
- d (5:6) Hebrew ephah, a dry measure of about 3/5 bushel (22 liters). Here it is the container that held that amount, a basket or barrel; so also in verses 7–11. It could not normally hold a person, which marks this as a vision.
- e (5:6) Hebrew “their eye.” The Septuagint has “their iniquity,” reading ʿawonam for ʿenam, a difference of one letter. Many translators follow it.
- f (5:7) Hebrew kikkar, “round thing,” the same word used for a talent, a weight of about 75 pounds (34 kilograms). Literally “a talent of lead”; the Septuagint has the same.
- g (5:11) Shinar is Babylonia (Genesis 10:10 and 11:2, the land of the tower of Babel). The Septuagint has “the land of Babylon.”

Chapter 6

1 And again I lifted up my eyes and saw, and behold, four chariots coming out from between two mountains! And the mountains were mountains of bronze. 2 With the first chariot were red horses, and with the second chariot black horses, 3 in the third chariot white horses, and in the fourth chariot spotted, strong horses.[a] 4 Then I answered and said to the angel who talked with me, “What are these, my lord?” 5 The angel replied, “These are heading out to the four winds of heaven, after standing in the presence of the Lord of the whole earth.[b] 6 The one with the black horses is going out to the land of the north, and the white have gone out after them,[c] and the dappled have gone out to the land of the south.” 7 And the strong ones went out and sought to go and walk to and fro through the earth. And he said, “Go, walk to and fro through the earth.” So they walked to and fro through the earth. 8 Then he called to me and said, “Look, those heading to the northern land have settled my Spirit in the northern land.”[d]

9 And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying, 10 “Take from the captivity, from Heldai, from Tobijah, and from Jedaiah, and come yourself on that same day; come to the house of Josiah son of Zephaniah, where they have arrived from Babylon.[e] 11 Take from them silver and gold, and make crowns,[f] and set it on the head of Joshua the son

of Jehozadak, the high priest. 12 And speak to him, saying, ‘Thus says Yahweh of Armies: See, a man whose name is Branch! From his place he shall sprout up,[g] and he shall build the temple of Yahweh. 13 He is the one who will construct Yahweh’s temple and wear majesty, and sit and govern from his throne. There will also be a priest at his throne,[h] and the two will share a peaceful understanding.’ 14 And the crown shall be for Helem and for Tobijah and for Jedaiah and for Hen son of Zephaniah, as a memorial in the temple of Yahweh.[i] 15 People from far away will come and help build Yahweh’s temple. Then you will recognize that Yahweh of Armies sent me to you. All this will happen if you faithfully listen to Yahweh your God.”

Notes

- a (6:3) The colors are uncertain. The Hebrew of the fourth group has two words (“dappled” and “strong”); the Septuagint has “piebald and ash-coloured.” In verse 7, “strong” (amutstsim) may be another color.
- b (6:5) Or “These are the four spirits of heaven.” The Hebrew ruhot means both “winds” and “spirits.”
- c (6:6) Or “toward the west” (literally “behind them”). The Hebrew does not mention a group going east.
- d (6:8) Or “have set my anger at rest.” The Hebrew is literally “have caused my spirit to rest.” The Septuagint has “my anger.”
- e (6:10) Heldai means “mole” or “enduring”; Tobijah, “Yahweh is good”; Jedaiah, “Yahweh knows”; Josiah, “Yahweh supports.” The Septuagint translates the names as common nouns: “from the chief men, and from the useful men of it, and from them that have understood it.”
- f (6:11) Hebrew ʿatarot is plural (“crowns”), but the verb “set” and the verb in verse 14 are singular. It may mean a single elaborate crown.
- g (6:12) Hebrew yitsmah, “he shall sprout,” a play on Tsemah, “Branch.” Compare 3:8.
- h (6:13) The Septuagint has “and there shall be a priest on his right hand.”
- i (6:14) Helem is probably Heldai (verse 10), and Hen (“grace”) is probably Josiah. Hen may also be translated “as a kindness to the son of Zephaniah.” The Septuagint has “to them that wait patiently … and for the favour of the son of Sophonias, and for a psalm in the house of the Lord.”

Chapter 7

1 In King Darius’s fourth year, Yahweh’s word came to Zechariah on the fourth day of the ninth month, Kislev (November–December).[a] 2 Now Bethel had sent Sharezer and Regem-melech and their men

to entreat the favor of Yahweh,[b] 3 saying to the priests of the house of Yahweh of Armies and to the prophets, "Shall I weep in the fifth month (in July–August), abstaining as I have done these many years?"[c]

4 Then the word of Yahweh of Armies came to me, saying, 5 "Speak to everyone in the land and to the priests: In the fifth and seventh months (September–October) of these seventy years, when you fasted and mourned, was it really for me that you fasted, for me?[d] 6 And when you eat and when you drink, is it not you who eat and you who drink? 7 Were not these the words that Yahweh proclaimed by the former prophets, when Jerusalem was inhabited and at ease, with her cities around her, and the Negev and the lowland were inhabited?"[e]

8 And the word of Yahweh came to Zechariah, saying, 9 "Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Judge with true justice; show steadfast love and compassion, each to his brother; 10 do not exploit the widow, the orphan, the foreigner, or the poor; and let none of you plan harm against a fellow Israelite in your heart." 11 But they would not pay attention; they turned a stubborn back and dulled their ears so they could not listen. 12 They made their hearts like adamant so as not to hear the law and the words that Yahweh of Armies had sent by his Spirit through the former prophets. Therefore great wrath came from Yahweh of Armies. 13 "And it came to pass that as he called and they would not hear, so they called and I would not hear," says Yahweh of Armies, 14 "and I scattered them with a storm wind among all the nations that they had not known. Thus the land was left desolate behind them, so that no one went to and fro, and they made the pleasant land a desolation."

Notes

- a (7:1) Kislev (Chislev) is the ninth month. As commonly reckoned, this was about December 7, 518 BC, nearly two years after the visions of 1:7–6:15.
- b (7:2) Or "Now Bethel-sharezer had sent Regem-melech and his men." Sharezer means "protect the king"; Regem-melech perhaps "friend of the king." The Septuagint has "And Sarasar and Arbeseer the king and his men sent to Bethel."
- c (7:3) Hebrew "in the fifth month," that is, Ab. The fast in this month mourned the burning of the temple in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:8–9). The Septuagint has "The holy offering has come in here in the fifth month."

- d (7:5) Hebrew “in the fifth and in the seventh,” that is, Ab and Tishri. The fast in the seventh month mourned the murder of Gedaliah (2 Kings 25:25).
- e (7:7) Hebrew Negev, “the dry country,” the south of Judah; and the Shephelah, “the lowland,” the low hills toward the coast.

Chapter 8

1 And the word of Yahweh of Armies came, saying, 2 “Thus says
Yahweh of Armies: I am jealous for Zion with great jealousy, and I am
jealous for her with great wrath. 3 Thus says Yahweh: I have returned
to Zion and will dwell in the midst of Jerusalem, and Jerusalem shall
be called the City of Faithfulness, and the mountain of Yahweh of
Armies, the Holy Mountain. 4 Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Old men
and old women will yet dwell in the broad places of Jerusalem, each
man with his staff in his hand for very age. 5 And the streets of the
city shall be full of boys and girls playing in its streets. 6 Thus says
Yahweh of Armies: If it is too wonderful in the eyes of the remnant of
this people in those days, should it also be too wonderful in my eyes?
declares Yahweh of Armies. 7 Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Behold, I
will save my people from the land of the sunrise and from the land of
the sunset,[a] 8 and I will bring them to dwell in the midst of Jerusalem.
And they shall be my people, and I will be their God, in faithfulness
and in righteousness.”
9 Thus says Yahweh of Armies: “Let your hands be strong, you who
hear in these days these words from the mouth of the prophets, which
were spoken in the day the house of Yahweh of Armies was founded,
that the temple might be built. 10 For before those days there were no
wages for people or for animals; and nobody who traveled was safe
from the enemy; I set everyone against his own neighbor. 11 But now
I will not deal with the remnant of this people as in the former days,
declares Yahweh of Armies. 12 For peace will be sown: the vine will
yield its fruit, the soil will give its harvest, and the skies will release
their dew. I will let the remnant of this people inherit all of this.[b] 13
And as you have been a curse among the nations, O house of Judah
and house of Israel, so will I save you, and you shall be a blessing. Do
not fear, but let your hands be strong.”

14 For this is what Yahweh of Armies says: "Just as I resolved to bring
calamity on you when your ancestors made me furious, and I did not
change my mind, says Yahweh of Armies, 15 so in these days I have
turned and purposed to do good to Jerusalem and to the house of
Judah. Fear not. 16 These are the things you are to do: Speak truth
each man with his neighbor; judge with truth and with a judgment of
peace in your gates. 17 Do not scheme harm against your neighbor in
your heart, and do not delight in perjury; for I hate all of these things,
declares Yahweh."
18 And the word of Yahweh of Armies came to me, saying, 19 "This is
what Yahweh of Armies says: The fasts of the fourth month (June–
July), the fifth, the seventh, and the tenth (December–January) will
become happy and joyful holidays for Judah's house, times of cheer-
ful celebration.[c] So cherish truth and peace.
20 "Thus says Yahweh of Armies: Peoples shall yet come, even the
inhabitants of many cities. 21 And the inhabitants of one will go to
another, saying, 'Let us go promptly to seek the favor of Yahweh, and
to seek Yahweh of Armies. I too will go.' 22 Many peoples and strong
nations shall come to seek Yahweh of Armies in Jerusalem and to
entreat the favor of Yahweh. 23 Thus says Yahweh of Armies: In those
days it shall be that ten men out of all the languages of the nations
shall grasp, yes, grasp the corner of the garment of a man who is a
Jew,[d] saying, 'We will go with you, for we have heard that God is
with you.'"

Notes

- a (8:7) Literally "from the land of the rising and from the land of the going in of the sun," that is, from east and west.
- b (8:12) Or "For there shall be the seed of peace." The Septuagint has "But I will show peace."
- c (8:19) Hebrew "the fast of the fourth, … the fifth, … the seventh, and … the tenth" months. The fourth month (Tammuz) mourned the breach of Jerusalem's wall (Jeremiah 39:2); the fifth (Ab), the temple's burning; the seventh (Tishri), Gedaliah's murder; and the tenth (Tebeth, December–January), the beginning of the siege (2 Kings 25:1). See 7:3, 7:5.
- d (8:23) Hebrew kanaph, the "corner" or "hem" of a garment, where tassels were worn (Numbers 15:38).

Chapter 9

1 An oracle.[a]
The word of Yahweh is against the land of Hadrach,
and Damascus is its resting place.
For to Yahweh is the eye of mankind
and of all the tribes of Israel;[b]
2 and Hamath also, which borders on it,
Tyre and Sidon, though they are very wise.
3 And Tyre built a fortress for herself,[c]
and piled up silver as the dust,
and gold as the mire of the streets.
4 Look, the Lord will dispossess her
and hurl her might into the sea,
and fire will consume her.
5 Ashkelon will see and be afraid,
and Gaza, and she will tremble greatly,
and Ekron, for her hope is put to shame.
A king will perish from Gaza,
and Ashkelon will not be lived in;
6 a mixed people shall dwell in Ashdod,[d]
and I will cut off the pride of the Philistines.
7 And I will remove his blood from his mouth,
and his detestable things from between his teeth,
and he too will be left over for our God;
he will be as a chief in Judah,[e]
and Ekron like the Jebusite.
8 And I will camp around my house as a garrison,
against any who pass through and return;
no taskmaster will pass through them again,
for now I have seen with my eyes.
9 Celebrate loudly, Zion's daughter!
Call out joyfully, Jerusalem's daughter!
See, your king comes to you;
he is just and brings deliverance,[f]

humble, mounted on a donkey,
on a young donkey, a donkey's foal.[g]
10 I will take away the chariot from Ephraim
and the warhorse from Jerusalem;
the warrior's bow will be snapped,
and he will proclaim peace to the nations;
his dominion will stretch from sea to sea,
and from the Euphrates to earth's farthest edges.[h]
11 As for you, because of the blood that sealed your covenant,
I will release your captives from the dry cistern.
12 Return to the stronghold, O prisoners of hope;
today also I declare that I will restore to you double.
13 For I have bent Judah as my bow;
I have filled the bow with Ephraim.
I will stir up your sons, O Zion,
against your sons, O Javan,[i]
and wield you like a warrior's sword.
14 Then Yahweh will appear over them,
and his arrow will go forth like lightning;
the Lord Yahweh will blow the ram's horn[j]
and will march in the storms of the south.
15 Yahweh of Armies will be a shield over them;
they will devour and will tread upon the stones of the sling;[k]
they will drink, they will roar as with wine,
and they will be filled like the basin,
like the corners of the altar.
16 And Yahweh their God will save them in that day
like a flock, his people;
for they are stones of a crown,
sparkling over his land.[l]
17 How good he is, and how lovely!
Grain will make the young men thrive,
and fresh wine the young women.

Notes

- a (9:1) Hebrew massa', "burden" or "oracle." Chapters 9–11 and 12–14 begin with the same heading, and Malachi 1:1 does too.
- b (9:1) Or "for Yahweh has an eye on mankind." The Hebrew is difficult. The Septuagint has "for the Lord looks upon men, and upon all the tribes of Israel." Hadrach was a region in Syria.
- c (9:3) Hebrew matsor, "stronghold," is a play on Tsor, "Tyre."
- d (9:6) Hebrew mamzer, a word of uncertain meaning, perhaps "people of mixed birth" or "foreigners." It appears elsewhere only in Deuteronomy 23:2.
- e (9:7) Or "like a chief" (Hebrew 'alluph). The Septuagint has "a captain of a thousand."
- f (9:9) Hebrew nosha', literally "saved" or "delivered," perhaps meaning "victorious." The Septuagint has "saving." "Humble" ('ani) also means "afflicted" or "poor"; the Septuagint has "meek."
- g (9:9) Quoted in Matthew 21:5 and John 12:15. Hebrew poetry often repeats an idea in two parallel lines (here, "on a donkey, on a colt"). Matthew's account mentions both a donkey and a colt (Matthew 21:2–7).
- h (9:10) Compare Psalm 72:8. "The River" is the Euphrates.
- i (9:13) Hebrew Yavan, Ionia, that is, the Greeks. The Septuagint has "the Greeks."
- j (9:14) Hebrew shophar. Here the divine name is Adonai YHWH, translated "the Lord Yahweh."
- k (9:15) Or "they shall devour and trample on the sling stones." The Hebrew is difficult. The Septuagint differs.
- l (9:16) The Hebrew is uncertain, and the verb may mean "sparkle" or "be raised like a banner." The Septuagint has "for holy stones are rolled upon his land."

Chapter 10

1 Ask of Yahweh rain
in the time of the latter rain;
Yahweh makes the lightning flashes,
and he gives them rain in showers,
to each man grass in the field.
2 For the teraphim have spoken iniquity,[a]
and the diviners have seen a lie,
and the dreams speak falsehood;
they comfort with vapor.
Therefore they have wandered off like a flock;
they are oppressed, for there is no shepherd.
3 "My anger is hot against the shepherds,
and I will punish the leaders;[b]

for Yahweh of Armies cares for his flock, the house of Judah,
and will make them like his majestic steed in battle.
4 From him shall come the cornerstone,
from him the tent peg,
from him the battle bow,
from him every ruler—all of them together.
5 And they will be like warriors,
trampling in the mire of the streets in war;
and they will fight, for Yahweh is with them,
and the riders of horses will be put to shame.
6 I will strengthen Judah's house,
and rescue Joseph's house,
and bring them back to live here, because I feel compassion for them;
it will be as though I had never rejected them;
for I am Yahweh their God, and I will respond to them.
7 And Ephraim will be like a warrior,
and their heart will be glad as with wine;
and their sons will see and be glad;
their heart will exult in Yahweh.
8 I will hiss for them and gather them,
for I have ransomed them;
and they will increase as they increased before.
9 And I will sow them among the peoples,
and in distant places they will remember me;
and they will live with their sons and will turn back.
10 And I will bring them back from the land of Egypt,
and from Assyria I will gather them;
and to the land of Gilead and Lebanon I will bring them,
and room will not be found for them.
11 He will cross the sea of trouble,
and beat down the sea's waves,
and the Nile's depths will all run dry;
Assyria's arrogance will be humbled,
and Egypt's scepter will vanish.

12 I will make them strong in Yahweh,
and they shall walk in his name,"[c] declares Yahweh.

Notes

- a (10:2) Hebrew teraphim, household idols used in divination (compare Genesis 31:19 and Ezekiel 21:21).
- b (10:3) Hebrew ʿattudim, "male goats," that is, the leaders of the flock.
- c (10:12) A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-g) reads "they shall glory in his name," and the Septuagint is similar ("they shall boast in his name").

Chapter 11

1 Open your doors, O Lebanon,
that the fire may devour your cedars!
2 Howl, O cypress, for the cedar is fallen,
because the majestic ones are laid waste!
Howl, O oaks of Bashan,
for the forest that could not be entered has come down![a]
3 Hark, the howling of the shepherds,
for their splendor is laid waste!
Hark, the roaring of young lions,
for the pride of the Jordan is laid waste![b]
4 Thus said Yahweh my God: "Shepherd the flock doomed to slaughter.
5 Their buyers butcher them and go unpunished, and their sellers declare, 'Praise Yahweh, I am rich!' and their own shepherds show them no compassion. 6 For I will no more pity the inhabitants of the land, declares Yahweh. But see, I am handing the men over, each one into his neighbor's hand and into his king's hand; and they shall beat the land to pieces, and from their hand I will not rescue." 7 So I shepherded the flock doomed to slaughter, truly the afflicted of the flock.[c] And I took two staffs; one I named Favor, and the other I named Union.[d] And I shepherded the flock. 8 And I made away with the three shepherds in one month.[e] And my soul was short with them, and their soul also abhorred me. 9 Then I said, "I will not feed you. The dying, let it die; and the perishing, let it perish; and those that remain, let them eat each one the flesh of her fellow." 10 Then I took my staff called Favor and snapped it in two, canceling the covenant I had made with all the nations. 11 So it was annulled on that day, and

the afflicted of the flock, who were watching me, knew that it was the word of Yahweh. 12 And I said to them, "If it is good in your eyes, give my hire; and if not, refrain." And they weighed my hire, thirty pieces of silver (about 12 ounces).[f] 13 And Yahweh said to me, "Cast it to the potter—the splendid price at which I was valued by them!" And I took the thirty pieces of silver and cast them to the potter in the house of Yahweh.[g] 14 Then I broke my second staff, even Union, so as to break the brotherhood between Judah and Israel.

15 And Yahweh said to me, "Take for yourself again the gear of a foolish shepherd.

16 For see, I am raising up a shepherd in the land; the perishing he will not visit, the young he will not seek, the broken he will not heal, the one standing he will not sustain; but the flesh of the fat he will eat, and he will tear off their hoofs.

17 Woe to the worthless shepherd,
who forsakes the flock!
A sword upon his arm
and upon his right eye!
His arm shall wither away completely,
and his right eye shall be dimmed completely!"

Notes

- a (11:2) Hebrew (Qere) "the inaccessible forest" or "the forest of the vintage" (Kethiv). The Hebrew is uncertain.
- b (11:3) Hebrew ge'on hayyarden, "the pride of the Jordan," that is, the thick growth along its banks (Jeremiah 12:5).
- c (11:7) Or, with a slightly different division of the Hebrew letters, "for the sheep merchants" (likena'ane hatstso'n); so also in verse 11. The Septuagint has "in the land of Canaan" here, and in verse 11 "the Canaanites."
- d (11:7) Hebrew No'am, "Favor" or "Pleasantness," and Hovelim, "Union" or "Binders." The Septuagint has "Beauty" and "Line."
- e (11:8) Who the three shepherds were is unknown. There have been many suggestions.
- f (11:12) Hebrew "thirty of silver," that is, thirty shekels. A shekel is about 0.4 ounce (11.5 grams), so the total is about 12 ounces (345 grams). This was the compensation for a slave gored by an ox (Exodus 21:32). Compare Matthew 26:15 and 27:3–10. Matthew 27:9 attributes the prophecy to Jeremiah; it combines this passage with themes from Jeremiah (18:2–3, 19:1–13, and 32:6–15).

- g (11:13) Hebrew yotser, "potter." The Syriac version reportedly has "treasury" ('otsar), a difference of one letter. Compare Matthew 27:6–7. The Septuagint has "Drop them into the furnace ... and cast them into the furnace in the house of the Lord." The phrase "the lordly price" is sarcastic.

Chapter 12

1 The burden of the word of Yahweh concerning Israel. The declaration of Yahweh, who spreads out the heavens and lays the foundation of the earth and shapes the spirit of man in his inward parts: 2 "See, I am making Jerusalem a bowl of reeling to all the peoples round about; and upon Judah also it will be, in the siege against Jerusalem.[a] 3 And in that day I will make Jerusalem a burdensome stone for all the peoples; all who lift it will be badly gashed; and all the nations of the earth will be gathered together against her. 4 On that day, declares Yahweh, I will afflict every horse with panic and its rider with insanity; but I will keep my eyes open over Judah's house, while I strike all the nations' horses with blindness. 5 And the chiefs of Judah will say in their heart, 'The inhabitants of Jerusalem are a strength to me in Yahweh of Armies their God.'

6 "In that day I will make the chiefs of Judah like a firepot among pieces of wood, and like a torch of fire among sheaves; and they will consume, on the right hand and on the left, all the peoples round about; and Jerusalem will yet dwell in her own place, in Jerusalem. 7 "Yahweh will rescue the tents of Judah first, so that the glory of David's house and of Jerusalem's residents will not exceed Judah's. 8 On that day Yahweh will defend those living in Jerusalem; the weakest among them on that day will be as strong as David, and David's house will be like God, like Yahweh's angel leading them. 9 And on that day I will seek to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem.

10 "I will pour out on David's house and on Jerusalem's residents a spirit of grace and pleading; they will look at me, whom they stabbed;[b] they will mourn for him as people mourn for an only child, and weep bitterly for him as people weep for a firstborn. 11 In that day the lamentation in Jerusalem will be great, like the lamentation of Hadad-rimmon in the valley of Megiddon.[c] 12 And the land will lament, clan

by clan apart: the clan of the house of David apart, and their women apart; the clan of the house of Nathan apart, and their women apart; 13 the clan of the house of Levi apart, and their women apart; the clan of the Shimeites apart, and their women apart; 14 all the clans that remain, clan by clan apart, and their women apart.

Notes

- a (12:2) Or "And Judah also will be in the siege against Jerusalem." The Hebrew is difficult.
- b (12:10) Some Hebrew manuscripts reportedly read "to him whom they have pierced," as John 19:37 quotes it (compare Revelation 1:7). The Septuagint has "they shall look upon me, because they have mocked me."
- c (12:11) Hadad-rimmon may be a place near Megiddo, or the name of a storm god (Hadad, also called Rimmon) whose mourning rites were well known. Some connect it with the national mourning for King Josiah, who was killed at Megiddo (2 Chronicles 35:22–25). The Septuagint has "the pomegranate grove cut down in the plain."

Chapter 13

1 "On that day a fountain will be opened to David's house and to Jerusalem's residents, to cleanse them from sin and defilement.[a]

2 "And it will be in that day, declares Yahweh of Armies, that I will cut off the names of the idols out of the land, and they will no more be remembered; and the prophets also and the unclean spirit I will make pass out of the land. 3 And it will be, if a man prophesies again, that his father and his mother who gave him birth will say to him, 'You will not live, for you have spoken falsehood in the name of Yahweh'; and his father and his mother who gave him birth will run him through when he prophesies. 4 And it will be in that day that the prophets will be ashamed, each one of his vision when he prophesies; and they will not wear a mantle of hair in order to lie. 5 He will say, 'I am no prophet; I am a farmer, because I have been someone's servant since I was young.'[b] 6 And one will say to him, 'What are these wounds between your hands?'[c] And he will say, 'Those with which I was struck at the house of those who love me.'

7 "O sword, wake up against my shepherd,
against the man who is my associate,"
declares Yahweh of Armies.

"Strike the shepherd, and the flock will scatter;[d]
and I will bring back my hand upon the little ones.
8 Throughout the whole land, declares Yahweh,
two thirds will be struck down and die,
and one third will survive.
9 That third I will pass through the fire,
refine them the way silver is refined,
and assay them the way gold is assayed.
They will invoke my name, and I will respond;
I will say, 'They are my people,'
and they will say, 'Yahweh is our God.'"

Notes

- a (13:1) Hebrew "for sin and for impurity." The second word (niddah) is used for ritual impurity.
- b (13:5) Or "for the land has been my possession since my youth" (reading a different word division). The Hebrew is difficult. The Septuagint has "for a man brought me up thus from my youth."
- c (13:6) Hebrew "between your hands," that is, on the chest or back. Such wounds were self-inflicted in ecstatic rites (1 Kings 18:28).
- d (13:7) Quoted in Matthew 26:31 and Mark 14:27. The Septuagint has "smite the shepherds, and draw out the sheep" (Codex Alexandrinus: "the shepherd").

Chapter 14

1 See, a day is coming that belongs to Yahweh, and your spoil will be shared out in your midst. 2 And I will gather all the nations to Jerusalem for war; and the city will be captured, and the houses looted, and the women violated; and half the city will go forth into captivity, but the remainder of the people will not be cut off from the city. 3 Then Yahweh will go out and fight against those nations as when he fights on a day of battle. 4 And his feet will stand in that day upon the Mount of Olives, which faces Jerusalem on the east; and the Mount of Olives will be split through its middle toward the east and toward the west into a very great valley; and half of the mountain will withdraw northward and half of it southward. 5 You will run to my mountain valley, for the valley between the mountains will extend to Azal.[a] You will run just as you ran from the earthquake in the time of

Uzziah, king of Judah.[b] Then Yahweh my God will arrive, with all his holy ones.[c]
6 On that day there shall be no light, cold, or frost.[d] 7 It will be a one-of-a-kind day, known only to Yahweh, neither daytime nor nighttime, yet when evening comes there will be light.
8 On that day fresh water will flow out of Jerusalem, some toward the eastern sea and some toward the western sea; it will flow in both summer and winter.[e] 9 And Yahweh will be king over all the earth. On that day Yahweh will be one and his name one.[f]
10 All the land will be changed into a level plain like the Arabah, from Geba to Rimmon, south of Jerusalem; and she will be raised high and will dwell in her place, from the Gate of Benjamin to the site of the First Gate, as far as the Corner Gate, and from the Tower of Hananel as far as the king's winepresses. 11 And they will dwell in her, and there will no more be a ban of destruction;[g] and Jerusalem will dwell securely.
12 And this will be the plague with which Yahweh will strike all the peoples who have warred against Jerusalem: he will make their flesh waste away while they stand on their feet, and their eyes will waste away in their holes, and their tongue will waste away in their mouth.
13 And it will be in that day that a great confusion from Yahweh will be among them; and they will grasp each man the hand of his neighbor, and his hand will rise up against his neighbor's hand. 14 And Judah also will fight in Jerusalem; and the riches of all the nations round about will be gathered: gold and silver and clothing in very great quantity.
15 And so will be the plague of the horse, the mule, the camel, and the donkey, and every beast that is in those camps: like this plague.
16 And it will be that every one left of all the nations that came against Jerusalem will go up year by year to bow down to the King, Yahweh of Armies, and to celebrate the Feast of Booths. 17 And if any of the families of the earth do not go up to Jerusalem to worship the King, Yahweh of Armies, there will be no rain on them. 18 And if the clan of Egypt does not go up and does not come, then not upon them;[h] there will be the plague with which Yahweh strikes the nations that do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths. 19 This will be the penalty of

Egypt, and the penalty of all the nations that do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths.

20 On that day the horses' bells will carry the inscription "Holy to Yahweh." The cooking pots in Yahweh's house will be as sacred as the bowls in front of the altar. 21 And every pot in Jerusalem and in Judah will be holy to Yahweh of Armies; and all who sacrifice will come and take from them and cook in them. And there will no longer be a trader[i] in the house of Yahweh of Armies in that day.

Notes

- a (14:5) Azal (or Azel) is an unknown place. The Septuagint has "And the valley of my mountains shall be closed up … and shall be blocked up," reading nistam ("shall be stopped up") for nastem ("you shall flee").
- b (14:5) Compare Amos 1:1. The earthquake was in the eighth century BC.
- c (14:5) Hebrew "with you." The Septuagint, the Latin Vulgate, and other ancient versions have "with him."
- d (14:6) Or "there shall be no light; the glorious ones shall congeal." The Hebrew is difficult. The Septuagint has "there shall be no light, and … cold and frost."
- e (14:8) The eastern sea is the Dead Sea; the western sea is the Mediterranean.
- f (14:9) Compare Deuteronomy 6:4 (the Shema): "Hear, O Israel: Yahweh our God, Yahweh is one."
- g (14:11) Hebrew herem, the ban that devoted something to destruction.
- h (14:18) The Hebrew is abrupt; the sense is probably "then no rain shall fall on them." The Septuagint omits "not" and reads "then upon them shall be the overthrow."
- i (14:21) Hebrew kena'ani, "Canaanite," also "merchant" (compare Proverbs 31:24).

Malachi

Old Testament

Chapter 1

1 A burden:[a] the word of Yahweh to Israel by the hand of Malachi.[b]
2 "I have loved you," says Yahweh. But you say, "In what way have
you loved us?" "Was not Esau brother to Jacob?" declares Yahweh.
"Yet I loved Jacob, 3 and Esau I hated;[c] and I have made his mountains
a waste and given his inheritance to the jackals of the wilderness."
4 Though Edom declares, "We have been crushed, but we will come
back and rebuild the ruins," Yahweh of Armies[d] replies: "Let them
build; I will demolish. They will be called 'Wicked Territory,' the
people Yahweh has cursed for all time." 5 You will witness it your-
selves, and you will declare, "Yahweh is great, even beyond Israel's
borders!"
6 "A son honors a father, and a servant his master. If then I am a father,
where is my honor? And if I am a master, where is the fear of me?
says Yahweh of Armies to you, O priests, who despise my name. And
you say, 'Wherein have we despised your name?' 7 By offering defiled
bread upon my altar. And you say, 'In what way have we defiled you?'
By your saying, 'The table of Yahweh is despicable.' 8 And when you
bring the blind to sacrifice, is it not evil? And when you bring the
lame and the sick, is it not evil? Bring it, I pray, to your governor;
will he be pleased with you, or lift up your face? says Yahweh of
Armies. 9 And now, entreat, I pray, the face of God, that he may be
gracious to us. From your hand this has come; will he lift up any of
your faces? says Yahweh of Armies. 10 Who is there even among you
that would shut the doors, so that you would not light my altar for
nothing? I have no delight in you, says Yahweh of Armies, and I will
not accept an offering from your hand. 11 From sunrise to sunset my
name is honored among the nations, and in every place incense and
a pure gift[e] are brought to my name; for my name is honored among

the nations, says Yahweh of Armies. 12 But you are profaning it when you say, 'The table of the Lord[f] is defiled, and its fruit, its food, is despicable.' 13 And you say, 'See, what a weariness!' and you sniff at it,[g] says Yahweh of Armies. And you bring what was torn, and the lame, and the sick; so you bring the offering. Should I accept it from your hand? says Yahweh. 14 Cursed be the cheat who has in his flock a male and vows it, and then sacrifices a blemished thing to the Lord. For I am a great King, says Yahweh of Armies, and my name is feared among the nations.

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew massa', "burden" or "oracle," a heavy pronouncement (compare Zechariah 9:1 and 12:1).
- b (1:1) Malachi means "my messenger" (compare 3:1). It may be the prophet's name or a title; the Septuagint has "by the hand of his messenger," and Jewish tradition (the Targum) identified the author with Ezra. The book is usually dated to the fifth century BC, after the second temple was built (515 BC) and probably before the reforms of Nehemiah.
- c (1:3) Quoted in Romans 9:13. In Hebrew idiom "love" and "hate" here express choosing and not choosing (compare Genesis 25:23).
- d (1:4) Hebrew YHWH Tseva'ot, traditionally "the LORD of hosts." The "armies" are the forces of heaven (the angels and the stars) and sometimes the armies of Israel. The title is translated "Yahweh of Armies" throughout.
- e (1:11) Or "will be offered." The Hebrew participles can be read as present or future. The Septuagint has "my name has been glorified among the nations; and in every place incense is offered."
- f (1:12) Hebrew Adonai, "Lord," also in verse 14. Some Hebrew manuscripts reportedly have YHWH here, and verse 7 has "the table of Yahweh."
- g (1:13) According to rabbinic tradition, this is one of the "corrections of the scribes" (tiqqune sopherim): the original reading was "you sniff at me," changed out of reverence. The Septuagint has "I have utterly scorned them."

Chapter 2

1 "And now, O priests, this commandment is for you. 2 If you refuse to listen, and refuse to take it to heart and honor my name, says Yahweh of Armies, I will send a curse on you and turn your blessings into curses. In fact, I already have, because you have not taken it to heart. 3 See, I am rebuking your seed,[a] and I will spread dung on your faces, the dung of your feasts; and one will carry you away to it. 4 And

you will know that I have sent this commandment to you, that my covenant may be with Levi, says Yahweh of Armies. 5 My covenant was with him, of life and of peace; and I gave them to him, for fear; and he feared me and stood in awe before my name. 6 The law of truth was in his mouth, and iniquity was not found on his lips; he walked with me in peace and in uprightness, and he turned many back from iniquity. 7 For the lips of a priest should guard knowledge, and they should seek the law from his mouth; for he is the messenger of Yahweh of Armies. 8 But you have turned aside out of the way; you have made many stumble in the law; you have corrupted the covenant of Levi, says Yahweh of Armies. 9 So I have made you contemptible and humiliated in front of everyone, since you do not follow my ways but play favorites when you teach the law."
10 Have we not all one father? Has not one God created us? Why then do we deal treacherously each man with his brother, to profane the covenant of our fathers? 11 Judah has dealt treacherously, and an abomination has been committed in Israel and in Jerusalem; for Judah has profaned the holy place of Yahweh, which he loves, and has married the daughter of a foreign god.[b] 12 May Yahweh cut off from the tents of Jacob the man who does this, him who wakes and him who answers,[c] and him who brings an offering to Yahweh of Armies.
13 And this second thing you do: you cover the altar of Yahweh with tears, with weeping and groaning, because he no longer turns to the offering or accepts it with favor from your hand. 14 And you say, "For what reason?" Because Yahweh has been witness between you and the wife of your youth, with whom you have dealt treacherously,[d] though she is your companion and the wife of your covenant. 15 Did he not make them a unity, with a share of spirit that is his? And what did that unity seek? Children who belong to God.[e] So protect your spirit, and let no one betray the wife he married in his youth. 16 "For he who hates and sends away,"[f] says Yahweh, the God of Israel, "covers his garment with violence," says Yahweh of Armies. So guard yourselves in your spirit, and do not deal treacherously.
17 You have worn Yahweh out[g] with your talk. Yet you ask, "How have we worn him out?" By claiming, "Everyone who does evil is good in

Yahweh's sight, and he is pleased with them," or by asking, "Where is the God of justice?"

Notes

- a (2:3) Or "your offspring." The Septuagint has "I will separate the shoulder from you," reading zeroa', "arm," for zera', "seed," and the Latin Vulgate has "I will throw the arm (shoulder) to you."
- b (2:11) That is, has married women who worship other gods.
- c (2:12) Hebrew 'er we'oneh, an obscure idiom, perhaps meaning "everyone." A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) reads 'ed, "witness," giving "witness and answerer" (that is, any advocate). The Septuagint has "until he is cast down."
- d (2:14) A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) lacks "with whom you have dealt treacherously."
- e (2:15) The Hebrew of this verse is very difficult, and the translation is uncertain. Another possible rendering is "Did not one God make her, flesh and spirit belonging to him? And what does the one God seek? Godly offspring." A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) reads "And you said, 'What is the one seeking?'"
- f (2:16) Hebrew ki sane' shallah, "for he hates, send away," which may also mean "For I hate divorce" (traditional rendering, reading the first verb as "I hate"). A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) reads "For if you hate, send her away," and then "they cover violence upon my garment." The Septuagint has "But if you hate her and send her away ... then ungodliness will cover your thoughts." Compare Deuteronomy 24:1–4.
- g (2:17) A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) has "And you have wearied God."

Chapter 3

1 "See, I am sending my messenger, and he will clear a way before me;[a] and suddenly the Lord[b] whom you are seeking will come to his temple, even the messenger of the covenant in whom you delight. See, he is coming, says Yahweh of Armies. 2 But who can endure the day of his coming? And who can stand when he appears? For he is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' lye. 3 And he will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver, and he will purify the sons of Levi and refine them like gold and like silver; and they will be to Yahweh those who bring offerings in righteousness. 4 Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem will be pleasing to Yahweh, as in the days of old and as in former years.

5 "I will approach you to hold court, and I will testify without delay against sorcerers, adulterers, and perjurers, against those who cheat

workers of their wages and exploit widows and orphans, against those who deny justice to the foreigner and have no reverence for me, says Yahweh of Armies.
6 "For I, Yahweh, have not changed; and you, O sons of Jacob, have not come to an end. 7 From the days of your fathers you have turned aside from my statutes and have not kept them. Return to me, and I will return to you, says Yahweh of Armies. But you say, 'In what way shall we return?' 8 Can a person cheat God?[c] Yet you are cheating me. You ask, 'How have we cheated you?' In tithes and offerings. 9 With the curse you are cursed, for you are robbing me, the whole nation of you. 10 Bring the full tenth to the storehouse so there is food in my house. Try me in this, says Yahweh of Armies: see whether I will fling open the windows of heaven and pour down blessing on you beyond what you can hold. 11 And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, and he shall not destroy the fruit of your ground, and the vine in the field will not be barren for you, says Yahweh of Armies. 12 Then every nation will call you fortunate, for yours will be a delightful land, says Yahweh of Armies.
13 "Your words have been strong against me, says Yahweh. Yet you say, 'What have we spoken among ourselves against you?' 14 You have said, 'It is vain to serve God. What gain is it that we have kept his charge and that we have walked as mourners before Yahweh of Armies? 15 And now we are calling the arrogant happy; not only are the doers of wickedness built up, but they test God and escape.'"
16 Then those who feared Yahweh spoke with one another. And Yahweh paid attention and heard, and a book of remembrance was written before him for those who feared Yahweh and esteemed his name. 17 "They will be mine, says Yahweh of Armies, in the day that I am preparing, a treasured possession;[d] and I will spare them as a man spares his son who serves him. 18 Then once more you will see the difference between the righteous and the wicked, between him who serves God and him who has not served him.

Notes

- a (3:1) Quoted in Mark 1:2, Matthew 11:10, and Luke 7:27, where it is applied to John the Baptist. "My messenger" (mal'akhi) is the same word as the name Malachi

(1:1). A Qumran Minor Prophets scroll (4QXII-a) begins the verse with "Therefore," and it is that scroll's reading that the verse begins a new section after 2:17.

- b (3:1) Hebrew ha'adon, "the Lord," not the divine name YHWH or the title Adonai. Here it is used of God himself, who comes to his own temple.
- c (3:8) Hebrew yiqba', "rob," perhaps a play on the name Jacob (ya'aqov, verse 6). The Septuagint has "Will a man insult God?" (probably reading ya'qov, "cheat"; compare Genesis 27:36).
- d (3:17) Hebrew segullah, the word used in Exodus 19:5 and Deuteronomy 7:6 for Israel as God's own treasured possession.

Chapter 4

1 "For see, the day is coming, burning like an oven,[a] and all the
arrogant and every doer of wickedness will be stubble; and the day
that is coming will set them ablaze, says Yahweh of Armies, so that it
will leave them neither root nor branch. 2 But for you who revere my
name, the sun of justice will rise, bringing healing in its rays;[b] and
you will go out leaping like calves released from the barn. 3 And you
will tread down the wicked, for they will be ashes under the soles of
your feet in the day that I am preparing, says Yahweh of Armies.
4 "Remember the law of Moses my servant, which I commanded him
at Horeb for all Israel, statutes and judgments.
5 "See, I am sending to you Elijah the prophet[c] before the coming of
the great and fearful day of Yahweh. 6 And he will turn the heart of
fathers to sons and the heart of sons to their fathers, lest I come and
strike the land with a ban of destruction."[d]

Notes

- a (4:1) Malachi 4:1–6 in English Bibles is 3:19–24 in the Hebrew Bible, which has only three chapters. The Septuagint, like the English Bible, has four chapters.
- b (4:2) Or "wings," meaning the rays of the sun. The image is of a winged sun disk, a common symbol in the ancient Near East. Compare Luke 1:78.
- c (4:5) Elijah means "My God is Yahweh." The Septuagint has "Elias the Tishbite" and places verse 4 ("Remember the law of Moses") after verse 6, at the end of the book. In Jesus' teaching the coming of Elijah is fulfilled in John the Baptist (Matthew 11:14; 17:10–13; Mark 9:11–13; compare Luke 1:17).
- d (4:6) Hebrew herem, the ban that devoted something to destruction. The Septuagint has "and the heart of a man to his neighbor, lest I come and strike the land utterly." Verse 6 is quoted in part in Luke 1:17. Because the book ends with a curse, in Jewish synagogue reading verse 5 is repeated after verse 6. In one Qumran Minor

Prophets scroll (4QXII-a), Malachi is reportedly followed by Jonah, so that in that copy it did not end the collection.

Tobit

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 The book of the words of Tobit,[a] the son of Tobiel,[b] the son of
Ananiel, the son of Aduel, the son of Gabael, the son of Raphael,[c] the
son of Raguel, from the line of Asiel, from the tribe of Naphtali, 2 who
in the days of Enemessar[d] king of the Assyrians was carried away
captive from Thisbe, which lies to the right[e] of Kedesh[f] of Naphtali in
Upper Galilee, above Asher,[g] behind the road toward the setting sun,
to the left of Phogor.
3 I, Tobit, walked in ways of truth and in righteous deeds all the
days of my life, and I did many acts of charity[h] for my kindred[i] and
for my people who had gone with me in the captivity into the land
of the Assyrians, to Nineveh. 4 When I was in my homeland, in the
land of Israel, still a young man, the whole tribe of my forefather[j]
Naphtali split away from the house of my forefather David and from
Jerusalem, the city picked from all Israel's tribes as the site where
all the tribes should offer sacrifice. The temple, God's dwelling place,
had been dedicated there, and it was built for every generation to
come. 5 All my kindred and the house of my ancestor Naphtali used to
sacrifice to the calf made by Jeroboam king of Israel at Dan,[k] on all the
mountains of Galilee. 6 But I alone, again and again, went to Jerusalem
for the festivals, as it is written for all Israel in an everlasting decree.
I would hurry off to Jerusalem carrying the first fruits and the first
yield of the crops, the tenth of the livestock, and the first shearings of
the sheep, 7 and I would hand them to the priests, the sons of Aaron,
for the altar. The tenth of the grain, of the wine and olive oil, of the
pomegranates and the figs, and of the rest of the fruit of the trees
I gave to the sons of Levi who ministered in Jerusalem. The second
tenth I converted into silver in each of the six years,[l] and I would
go and spend it in Jerusalem year by year. 8 I gave the third tenth[m]

to the orphans and the widows and to the converts who had joined themselves to Israel; every third year I brought it in and gave it to them, and we ate it according to the decree set down about it in the law of Moses and with the directions that Deborah,[n] the mother of our ancestor Ananiel, had given, because when my father died he left me fatherless.

9 When I came of age I took a wife from the descendants of our own family, and I fathered a son by her, and I named him Tobias.[o] 10 After I was carried captive to Assyria, when I was taken as a captive and came to Nineveh, all my kindred and those of my own people were eating the food[p] of the nations, 11 but I guarded myself[q] and did not eat the food of the nations. 12 Because I was mindful of my God with my whole heart,[r] 13 the Most High granted me favor and good standing[s] in the presence of Enemessar, and I became his buyer of everything he needed. 14 I used to travel to Media and buy for him from there until he died. While in the land of Media I left bags of silver amounting to about 750 pounds[t] in the keeping of Gabael,[u] the brother of Gabri. 15 But when Enemessar died and his son Sennacherib[v] became king in his place, the roads into Media became unsafe,[w] and I could no longer travel to Media.

16 In the days of Enemessar I did many acts of charity for my kindred, those of my own people. 17 I would give my food to the hungry and clothing to the naked, and if I saw that one of my people had died and had been thrown out behind the wall of Nineveh, I would bury him. 18 I also buried any whom Sennacherib killed when he came back in flight from Judea, in the days of the judgment that the King of heaven carried out on him for the blasphemies he had spoken.[x] For in his anger he put many of the Israelites to death; and I would steal their bodies and bury them, and Sennacherib searched for them but did not find them. 19 Then one of the people of Nineveh went and reported me to the king, saying that it was I who buried them, and I hid myself. When I found out that the king had learned about me and that I was being sought for execution, I was afraid, and I ran away. 20 Everything I owned was seized; nothing at all was left to me that was not carried off to the royal treasury, except my wife Anna[y] and my son Tobias.

21 But before forty days[z] had gone by, two of his sons murdered him
and escaped to the mountains of Ararat. And his son Esarhaddon[aa]
reigned after him. He appointed Ahikar,[ab] the son of my brother
Anael, over the entire accounting of his kingdom, and he held
authority over the whole administration. 22 Then Ahikar spoke up for
me, and I went back down to Nineveh. Now Ahikar had been chief
cupbearer, keeper of the signet ring,[ac] administrator, and treasurer
under Sennacherib king of the Assyrians, and Esarhaddon kept him
on as second in rank.[ad] He was my nephew[ae] and one of my own
relatives.

Notes

- a (1:1) Tobit: Greek Tōbith; the shorter Greek recension (GI, Codex Vaticanus and Codex Alexandrinus) spells it Tōbit. The name probably represents Hebrew Tobi, "my good," perhaps short for Tobiyah, "Yahweh is my good"; the Qumran Aramaic copies of Tobit are reported to spell it Tobi. This translation follows the longer Greek recension (GII) of Codex Sinaiticus throughout; footnotes note where the shorter GI differs significantly.
- b (1:1) Tobiel: "God is my good." Ananiel means "God has been gracious"; Aduel and Gabael are of uncertain meaning; Raguel means "friend of God"; Asiel means "God has made."
- c (1:1) Raphael: "God heals" (Hebrew rafaʾ, "heal," plus ʾel, "God"), here an ancestor of Tobit; the same name is borne by the angel who appears in chapter 3. GI lacks "son of Raphael, son of Raguel."
- d (1:2) Enemessar: the Greek form of the name of Shalmaneser V, king of Assyria 727–722 B.C. Historically the people of Naphtali were deported by his predecessor Tiglath-pileser III about 733/732 B.C. (2 Kings 15:29); the book's chronology is not precise.
- e (1:2) To the right: that is, to the south, for one facing east.
- f (1:2) Kedesh: Greek Kydiōs, Kedesh in Naphtali (Joshua 20:7). GI lacks "Upper" and the rest of the verse after "Asher."
- g (1:2) Asher: Greek Assēr; many take this to be Hazor (compare 2 Kings 15:29). Phogor, later in the verse, is of uncertain location (perhaps Peor); scholarly review recommended.
- h (1:3) Acts of charity: Greek eleēmosynai, "acts of mercy, almsgiving," a key word in Tobit.
- i (1:3) Kindred: Greek "brothers," here fellow Israelites, as often in this book.
- j (1:4) Ancestor: Greek "father," here and in "my ancestor David."
- k (1:5) The calf that Jeroboam made: see 1 Kings 12:28–30. GI reads "All the tribes that broke away together sacrificed to Baal, the heifer," and lacks "on all the mountains of Galilee."

- l (1:7) In each of the six years: Greek "for the six years," of uncertain sense; perhaps the six years of the seven-year cycle other than the sabbatical year. On the second tenth (tithe), eaten in Jerusalem, see Deuteronomy 14:22–26. GI says only that he sold the second tenth. Scholarly review recommended.
- m (1:8) The third tenth: Greek "it"; compare Deuteronomy 14:28–29 and 26:12. GI reads "the third I gave to those to whom it was due."
- n (1:8) Deborah: "bee." GI calls her "my father's mother." Since Ananiel was Tobit's grandfather (verse 1), "the mother of our ancestor Ananiel" would make Deborah his great-grandmother.
- o (1:9) Tobias: from Hebrew Tobiyah, "Yahweh is good." GI names Tobit's wife, Anna, here.
- p (1:10) Food: Greek "breads," bread standing for food in general, here and in verse 11.
- q (1:11) Guarded myself: Greek "kept my soul."
- r (1:12) Heart: Greek "soul." Sinaiticus reads "and when I was mindful"; GI reads "because I remembered God."
- s (1:13) Good standing: Greek morphē, "form, appearance," here the impression he made.
- t (1:14) About 750 pounds: Greek "ten talents of silver," about 340 kilograms; reckoned at about 75 pounds (34 kilograms) to the talent. On the Attic standard a talent was 6,000 drachmas, so ten talents were about 60,000 days' wages for a laborer, an enormous fortune. GI adds "at Rages in Media."
- u (1:14) Gabael: meaning uncertain; GI spells his brother's name Gabrias.
- v (1:15) Sennacherib: king of Assyria 705–681 B.C. He was in fact the son of Sargon II, who followed Shalmaneser V (Enemessar).
- w (1:15) Became unsafe: Greek "broke away" (S) or "became unsettled" (GI).
- x (1:18) The blasphemies he had spoken: see 2 Kings 18:13–19:37 and Isaiah 36–37.
- y (1:20) Anna: the Greek form of Hannah, "grace, favor."
- z (1:21) Forty days: GI reads "fifty days." On the murder of Sennacherib see 2 Kings 19:37.
- aa (1:21) Esarhaddon: Greek Sacherdonos; king of Assyria 681–669 B.C.
- ab (1:21) Ahikar: Greek Achicharos (GI Achiacharos), the wise courtier who is the hero of the ancient Story of Ahikar, known from an Aramaic papyrus found at Elephantine in Egypt (fifth century B.C.) and from many later versions. A cuneiform tablet from Uruk is reported to name a scholar of Esarhaddon's time "whom the Arameans call Ahuqar." Tobit makes him a kinsman (see also 2:10; 11:18; 14:10). Anael is of uncertain meaning.
- ac (1:22) Keeper of the signet ring: Greek "over the ring," the officer responsible for the king's seal.
- ad (1:22) Second in rank: or "a second time"; the Greek ek deuteras can mean either. GI calls Ahikar only "the cupbearer" and lacks "under Sennacherib king of the Assyrians."

- ae (1:22) Nephew: Greek exadelphos, usually "cousin," but here a brother's son, as in verse 21. GI lacks "and one of my own relatives."

Chapter 2

1 So in the reign of Esarhaddon I came back to my house, and Anna my
wife and Tobias my son were restored to me. On our feast of Pente-
cost,[a] the holy Feast of Seven Weeks, a fine dinner was made ready
for me, and I took my place at the table. 2 The table was set before me,
with many delicacies laid out on it, and I said to my son Tobias, "My
child, go, and if you find any poor man among our kindred, among
the captives from Nineveh,[b] who is mindful of God with his whole
heart,[c] bring him, and he will eat together with me. See, child, I will
wait for you until you come back." 3 So Tobias went to look for some
poor man among our kindred. He came back and said, "Father!" And
I said to him, "Here I am, my child." He answered, "Father, look, one
of our people has been murdered and thrown out in the marketplace,
and he was strangled right there just now." 4 I jumped up and left the
dinner before I had tasted any of it. I took him up from the square
and laid him in one of the outbuildings until the sun went down, so
that I could bury him. 5 Then I came back, washed myself, and ate
my food in mourning. 6 And I remembered the saying of the prophet,
the words Amos had spoken against Bethel:[d] "Your festivals will be
turned into mourning, and all your songs into a lament." And I wept.
7 When the sun had set, I went off, dug a grave, and buried him.
8 My neighbors laughed at me and said, "He is not afraid anymore!
He was already hunted to be put to death for this very thing, and he
ran away; and look, here he is burying the dead again!" 9 That same
night I bathed, went into my courtyard, and lay down to sleep beside
the courtyard wall, with my face uncovered because of the heat.[e] 10
I did not know that there were sparrows on the wall above me, and
their warm droppings settled in my eyes and brought on white films.[f]
I went to the physicians to be cured, but the more they smeared their
ointments on me, the more my eyes were blinded by the white films,
until I lost my sight entirely. For four years I could not see. All my

kindred grieved for me, and Ahikar provided for me for two years before he went to Elymais.[g]

11 At that time my wife Anna took in women's work for hire.[h] 12 She would deliver it to the owners, and they would pay her wages. On the seventh day of Dystrus (February–March)[i] she cut the woven piece off the loom and delivered it to the owners, and they paid her the full wage and also gave her a young goat from their flock for a meal.[j] 13 When she came to me, the young goat started bleating. I called out and asked her, "Where did this young goat come from? You did not steal it, did you? Hand it back to the owners, because eating stolen goods is forbidden to us." 14 She told me, "It was handed to me as a present, over and above my wages." But I did not believe her, and I kept telling her to give it back to the owners, and I flushed with anger at her over it. Then she retorted, "So what of your acts of charity? What of your righteous deeds? Look, all this about you is plain to see!"[k]

Notes

- a (2:1) Pentecost: Greek pentēkostē, "fiftieth," the Festival of Weeks, seven weeks after Passover (Leviticus 23:15–21; Deuteronomy 16:9–10), in late spring (May–June).
- b (2:2) Among the captives from Nineveh: or "among the Ninevite captives." GI is much shorter in verses 2–5.
- c (2:2) Mindful of God with his whole heart: Greek "who remembers with his whole heart"; GI reads "who is mindful of the Lord."
- d (2:6) Amos … against Bethel: Amos 8:10. Bethel means "house of God." GI reads "I remembered the prophecy of Amos" and has "all your merrymaking" for "all your songs."
- e (2:9) Because of the heat: GI instead says that, having buried him, he lay down "defiled" (compare Numbers 19:11–13) by the courtyard wall, with his face uncovered.
- f (2:10) White films: Greek leukōmata, white opacities over the eyes, apparently a form of corneal scarring. GI is shorter: "the physicians did not help me," and lacks the four years and the two years.
- g (2:10) Elymais: the region of ancient Elam, east of Babylonia.
- h (2:11) Took in women's work for hire: Greek ēritheueto, "worked for wages," probably at spinning and weaving.

- i (2:12) Seventh day of Dystrus: Dystrus was a month of the Macedonian calendar, corresponding roughly to the Jewish month Adar (February–March). Sinaiticus alone gives the date and the details of the loom.
- j (2:12) For a meal: Greek "for the hearth," of uncertain sense; perhaps "for a festive meal."
- k (2:14) These things are well known about you: or "See, everything about you is known!" The sense of Anna's retort is debated; she may mean that everyone now sees how his good deeds have turned out. GI reads "Look, everything about you is known." Scholarly review recommended.

Chapter 3

1 Then, sick at heart[a] and groaning, I wept, and with groans I began
to pray: 2 "You are righteous, O Lord,[b] and all your deeds are right-
eous, and all your ways are mercy and truth; you are the judge of
the world.[c] 3 And now, O Lord, remember me and look on me. Do
not punish me for my sins and for my unintentional errors, or for
those of my ancestors, who sinned before you 4 and disobeyed your
commandments. You handed us over to plunder, to captivity, and to
death, and made us a byword, a thing for gossip, and an object of
scorn among all the nations among whom you have scattered us. 5
And now your many judgments are true in dealing with me for my
sins, because we have not kept your commandments and have not
walked in truth before you. 6 So now treat me however you see fit,
and order my spirit taken from me, so that I may leave the earth and
become dust.[d] Death is better for me than life, since I have had to
listen to groundless insults, and my sorrow is huge. Lord, command
that I be freed from this misery; send me to my eternal home, and do
not turn your face from me, Lord. Death is better for me than seeing
so much misery in my life and hearing such taunts."
7 That same day it happened that Sarah,[e] the daughter of Raguel
who lived in Ecbatana[f] in Media, also heard insults, from one of her
father's maidservants. 8 For she had been married to seven husbands,
and Asmodeus,[g] the evil demon, had killed each of them before he
could sleep with her as husbands normally do. The maid told her,
"You are the one who kills your husbands! Look, seven husbands
have already had you, and you have not had the name of even one
of them.[h] 9 Why are you lashing out at us? Because your husbands

are dead? Go and join them! May we never see a son or a daughter of yours!" 10 That day she was heartbroken to the core and wept. She climbed to her father's upstairs room, intending to hang herself. But she reconsidered and said, "No; people might mock my father and tell him, 'You had one dear daughter, and she hanged herself because of her wretchedness.' Then I would send my aged father to Hades[i] in grief. It is better not to hang myself, but to plead with the Lord that I may die, so that I need not hear such taunts for the rest of my life." 11 At that moment, stretching out her hands toward the window, she prayed: "You are blessed, compassionate God, and your name is blessed forever; may all you have made bless you forever. 12 And now I have lifted my face and my eyes to you. 13 Give the word that I be released from the earth, so that I no longer have to hear insults. 14 You know, Master, that I am pure of any defilement with a man, 15 and I have not tarnished my own name or my father's name in the country where I am a captive. I am my father's only child; there is no other child to inherit from him, and no near relative or kinsman for whom I might preserve myself as a wife.[j] Seven husbands of mine have already died; why should I go on living? But if you are not willing to end my life, Lord, then hear the taunts I endure."[k]

16 At that very time the prayers of both of them were heard in the presence of the glory of God.[l] 17 And Raphael was sent to heal the two of them: to strip the white films from Tobit's eyes, so that with his own eyes he might see God's light; and to give Sarah, Raguel's daughter, as wife to Tobias son of Tobit, and to set her free from Asmodeus the evil demon,[m] because Tobias had the right to marry her before all others who wanted to take her. At that same moment Tobit came back from the courtyard into his house, and Sarah daughter of Raguel came down from the upper room.

Notes

- a (3:1) Sick at heart: Greek "grieved in soul." GI reads "And in grief I wept and prayed in anguish, saying."
- b (3:2) Lord: Greek kyrios, which in the Greek scriptures regularly stands for the divine name YHWH of the Hebrew text. Since Tobit survives complete only in Greek (and its Semitic original only in fragments), this translation renders kyrios as "Lord" throughout. Scholarly review recommended.

- c (3:2) You are the judge of the world: or "you judge forever." GI reads "and you render true and righteous judgment forever."
- d (3:6) Turn to dust: Greek "become earth."
- e (3:7) Sarah: Hebrew Sarah, "princess." Greek Sarra.
- f (3:7) Ecbatana: the capital of Media (modern Hamadan in Iran).
- g (3:8) Asmodeus: Greek Asmodaios (GI Asmodaus), probably from Avestan aēshma-daēva, "demon of wrath," the demon of fury in Persian tradition; some instead derive it from Hebrew shamad, "destroy." In later Jewish tradition he appears as Ashmedai, king of the demons.
- h (3:8) You have not borne the name of a single one of them: Greek ouk ōnomasthēs, "you have not been named for one of them," that is, none has lived to give you his name and a family. GI reads ouk ōnasthēs, "you have not had the benefit of one of them."
- i (3:10) Hades: the Greek name for the realm of the dead, corresponding to Hebrew Sheol.
- j (3:15) For whom I should keep myself as a wife: marriage within the clan was expected; see 4:12–13 and Numbers 36:6–9. GI reads "no close kinsman nor any son of his."
- k (3:15) Listen now to the insults I suffer: Greek "hear my reproach." GI reads "command that I be looked on with pity, and that I no longer hear reproach."
- l (3:16) The glory of God: GI reads "the glory of the great Raphael."
- m (3:17) Set her free from Asmodeus the evil demon: GI reads "to bind Asmodeus the evil demon" (compare 8:3).

Chapter 4

1 That day Tobit called to mind the silver he had deposited with Gabael
at Rages[a] in Media, 2 and he said to himself, "Look, I have asked for
death. Why not call my son Tobias and explain to him about this silver
before I die?" 3 So he summoned Tobias his son, and when the boy
came, he told him, "Bury me properly. Show honor to your mother;
do not forsake her for the rest of her days. Do whatever pleases her,
and never cause her spirit grief in any matter. 4 Remember her, my
child, for she went through many dangers on your account while she
carried you in her womb. And when she dies, lay her beside me in
the same grave.
5 "Every day you live, my child, keep the Lord in mind, and do not
choose to sin or to break his commandments. Practice righteousness
throughout your life, and never walk in the paths of wrongdoing, 6 for
those who act faithfully will prosper in what they do. 7 To everyone

who does what is right[b] give alms from what you own, and never
let your eye be stingy when you give alms. Do not look away from
any poor person, and God's face will not look away from you. [8] Give
charity in proportion to what you have: if you have much, give from
your abundance; if you have little, do not be afraid to give charity
even from that little. [9] For in this way you store up a good treasure for
yourself against the day of need, [10] because charity rescues from death
and keeps one from going into the darkness. [11] Indeed, for all who
practice it, charity is a worthy offering in the sight of the Most High.
[12] "Guard yourself, my child, against all sexual immorality. Above
all, marry a woman of your ancestors' stock; do not take a foreign
wife, one who is not from your father's tribe, for we are the sons of
prophets. Remember, my child, that Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob,
our forefathers from the beginning, each married a woman of his own
kin, and they were blessed in their children, and their offspring will
possess the land. [13] So now, my child, love your kindred, and do not
be too proud at heart to take a wife for yourself from among your
kindred, the sons and daughters of your people. For in pride there is
ruin and great disorder, and in idleness there is loss and dire want, for
idleness is the mother of famine. [14] Do not hold back a worker's pay
overnight, but pay him immediately. If you serve God, he will reward
you. Be careful, my child, in all you do, and be well trained in all your
behavior. [15] And whatever you hate, do it to no one. Drink no wine
to the point of drunkenness, and do not let drunkenness travel along
with you on your way. [16] Share your food with the hungry and your
clothing with those who have none. Whatever you have in excess,
give as charity, and do not let your eye be grudging when you give
charity. [17] Pour out your bread on the tomb of the righteous,[c] but give
nothing to sinners. [18] Seek advice from every sensible person, and do
not scorn any useful counsel. [19] Bless the Lord God at every season,
and pray to him to make your ways straight and to bring success to all
your paths and purposes. For wisdom does not belong to any nation;[d]
it is the Lord who will give them good counsel. But whomever the
Lord wishes, he brings low, even to the lowest depths of Hades. So

now, my child, keep these commandments in memory, and let them never be wiped from your heart.
20 "And now, my child, I am making known to you that I left about 750 pounds of silver[e] in trust with Gabael son of Gabri at Rages in Media.
21 Do not be afraid, my child, that we have fallen into poverty. Great riches are yours if you fear God, run from every sin, and do what is good before the Lord your God."

Notes

- a (4:1) Rages: a city of Media, near modern Tehran (ancient Rhagae, modern Rey).
- b (4:7) To all who practice righteousness: at this point Sinaiticus passes directly from these words (verse 7) to "the Lord will give them good counsel" (verse 19), apparently through a scribe's accidental omission. The remainder of verse 7, verses 8–18, and the first part of verse 19 (through "does not belong to any nation") are translated from GI (Vaticanus and Alexandrinus). Fragments of this section are reported to survive among the Qumran copies (4Q200). Scholarly review recommended.
- c (4:17) Pour out your bread on the tomb of the righteous: probably a reference to providing food for the mourners at the funeral of the righteous (compare Jeremiah 16:7); the sense is debated.
- d (4:19) Wisdom does not belong to any nation: Greek "every nation does not have counsel," translated from GI. GI then reads "but the Lord himself gives all good things, and whomever he wishes he humbles, as he pleases." The rest of the verse follows Sinaiticus.
- e (4:20) About 750 pounds of silver: Greek "ten talents of silver," about 340 kilograms; see the note on 1:14.

Chapter 5

1 Then Tobias answered his father Tobit, "Father, I will do everything you have commanded me. 2 But how can I recover it from him, seeing that the man has never met me and I have never met him? What token shall I show him, so that he knows who I am and believes me and pays out the silver? Besides, the roads into Media are unknown to me; how am I to get there?" 3 Tobit replied to Tobias his son, "He gave me his signature on a bond, and I gave him mine; I tore it in two, and each of us kept a half, and I put my half with the silver.[a] And now twenty years have gone by since I left this silver in his care. So now, my child, look for a dependable man to accompany you, and we will pay him wages till you come home; then fetch this silver from him."

4 Tobias went out, then, in search of someone to make the journey
to Media with him, a man acquainted with the road. And going out
he found Raphael the angel standing right before him, though he had
no idea that this was an angel of God. 5 Tobias said to him, "Where
are you from, young man?" He replied, "From the Israelites, your
kindred, and I have come here to look for work." Tobias said to him,
"Do you know the road that goes to Media?" 6 He answered, "Yes; I
have been there many times, I am familiar with it, and I know all the
routes. I have gone to Media often, and I used to lodge with Gabael
our kinsman, who lives at Rages in Media. From Ecbatana to Rages
is a regular two days' journey,[b] since Rages lies in the mountains." 7
Tobias said, "Stay here for me, young man, while I go inside and let
my father know, because I need you to come with me on the road,
and I will see that you are paid." 8 He said to him, "Very well, I will
stay here; only do not be long."
9 So Tobias went in and told his father Tobit, "Listen, I have found a
man from among our kindred, the Israelites." Tobit said to him, "Call
the man in to me, so that I may learn what his family is and what
tribe he is from, and whether he is reliable enough to go with you, my
child." 10 So Tobias went out and called him: "Young man, my father
wants you." He went in, and Tobit was the first to greet him. The
young man said to him, "I wish you much joy!" But Tobit answered
him, "What joy is left to me anymore? I am a man whose eyes have
failed; the light of the sky is hidden from me, and I lie in the dark like
the dead, who never again behold the light. I live, yet I dwell among
the dead. I hear human voices, yet I cannot see the speakers." The
young man said to him, "Take courage; God will soon heal you. Take
courage." Then Tobit told him, "Tobias, my son, wishes to travel to
Media. Can you go with him and guide him? I will pay what you are
owed, brother." He replied, "I am able to go with him; every road is
known to me. Many times I have made the trip to Media and have
crossed all its plains and its mountains; I know every road there." 11
Then Tobit said to him, "Brother, what family are you from, and from
what tribe? Tell me, brother." 12 He said, "What need do you have of
a tribe?" Tobit said to him, "I want to know truly whose son you are,

brother, and what your name is." 13 He answered, "I am Azariah,[c] son
of Hananiah the great, from among your kindred." 14 Then Tobit said
to him, "Welcome, and may you be safe and well, brother! Do not
take it amiss, brother, that I wished to learn the truth of your lineage.
As it happens, you are a kinsman, and from a fine and worthy family.
Hananiah and Nathan, the two sons of Shemeliah[d] the great, were
known to me; they would make the pilgrimage to Jerusalem with me
and bow in worship beside me there, and they never strayed. Good
men, your kindred! Good is the root you spring from. Welcome!" 15
Then he said to him, "I will pay you a wage of a drachma[e] a day,
and your expenses, as I do for my son. 16 Go along with my son, and
I will add still more to your pay." 17 He replied, "I will go with him;
have no fear. We will leave in good health and come back to you in
good health, for the road is safe." Tobit said to him, "Blessings on you,
brother!" Next he summoned his son and told him, "My child, make
ready what the road requires and set off with your kinsman. May the
God who is in heaven keep you safe there and bring you home to me
unharmed, and may his angel travel at your side to protect you, my
child." So Tobias went out to begin his journey; he kissed his father
and mother, and Tobit said to him, "Go in good health."[f]
18 At this his mother burst into tears and said to Tobit, "Why did you
send my boy away? Is he not the staff we lean on, coming and going
in our sight? 19 Do not let money be added to money;[g] let it rather be
counted as nothing beside our child. 20 The life the Lord has granted
us is enough for us." 21 But he said to her, "Do not worry. Our child
will go in good health and return to us in good health. On the day
he comes back to you unharmed, you will see him with your own
eyes. 22 Do not worry; have no fear for them, my sister.[h] A good angel
will keep him company; he will have a prosperous journey and will
return unharmed." 23 And she stopped weeping.

Notes

- a (5:3) He gave me his signature … with the silver: the deposit was secured by a written bond, signed by both parties and cut in two so that the halves could later be matched. GI is much shorter in verses 2–3.

- b (5:6) Two days from Ecbatana to Rages: in fact the distance from Ecbatana (Hamadan) to Rages (near Tehran) is about 185 miles (300 kilometers), and Ecbatana, not Rages, lies on the higher ground; the book's geography is not exact.
- c (5:13) Azariah: "Yahweh has helped." Hananiah means "Yahweh has been gracious." Greek Azarias son of Ananias. The angel takes a fitting name, since he has come to help (compare 12:15).
- d (5:14) Shemeliah: Greek Semelios, perhaps for Hebrew Shemaiah ("Yahweh has heard"); GI reads Semeias, and Jathan for Nathan ("he has given").
- e (5:15) A drachma: a Greek silver coin of about 4.3 grams (0.15 ounce), the usual daily wage of a laborer in the Hellenistic period. In modern terms, one drachma was roughly a day's pay for an unskilled worker; its silver content alone would be worth only a few dollars today. GI has Tobit ask "what wage shall I pay you?" before naming the drachma.
- f (5:17) Go in good health: GI is much shorter in this verse and adds, "and the young man's dog went along with them." Sinaiticus mentions the dog at 6:1.
- g (5:19) Do not let money be added to money: the Greek is obscure; literally "may silver not reach silver (or 'come first before silver'), but let it be the offscouring of our child," that is, may the money be counted as worthless compared with our son. GI has the same wording.
- h (5:22) My sister: a term of affection for his wife (compare 7:15; 8:4, 7).

Chapter 6

1 So the lad left home with the angel beside him, and the dog left with
him too[a] and followed after them. The pair traveled on until night fell
for the first time, and they halted for the night by the river Tigris. 2
The young man went down to the Tigris to wash his feet, and a great
fish sprang from the water, eager to gulp down the boy's foot, and
he shouted. 3 But the angel told the young man, "Seize it! Get a firm
hold on the fish!" So the young man overpowered the fish and hauled
it up onto the bank. 4 Then the angel said to him, "Slit the fish open
and take out its gall, its heart, and its liver, and keep them by you,
but throw the entrails away. For the gall, the heart, and the liver are
useful as medicine." 5 The young man cut the fish open and gathered
up the gall, the heart, and the liver. He roasted part of the fish and ate
it, and he salted the rest and kept it.
6 Then the two of them traveled on together until they drew near to
Media. 7 And then the young man put a question to the angel: "Brother
Azariah, what is the medicine in the heart and the liver of the fish,
and in its gall?" 8 He told him, "As for the heart and the liver of the

fish, burn them so that their smoke rises before any man or woman who suffers an assault from a demon or an evil spirit, and every such assault will flee from that person, and they will never stay with him again. 9 And as for the gall, use it to anoint the eyes of a person on whose eyes white films have formed; blow on the films, on the eyes themselves, and they become well."

10 When he had entered Media and was already approaching Ecbatana,[b] 11 Raphael said to the young man, "Brother Tobias!" He answered, "Here I am." Raphael told him, "Tonight we must lodge at the home of Raguel. The man is your relative, and he has a daughter named Sarah. 12 He has no male heir and no other daughter besides Sarah alone, and you, more than anyone else, are her nearest kinsman with the right to marry her.[c] The right to inherit her father's possessions also falls justly to you. The girl is sensible, courageous, and very beautiful, and her father is a good man." 13 And he went on, "You have the right to take her. Hear me, then, brother: this night I will talk with her father concerning the girl, to secure her as a bride for you; and once we are back from Rages we will hold her wedding. I am certain that Raguel cannot in any way withhold her from you or pledge her to someone else; he would incur the penalty of death under the ruling of the book of Moses,[d] because he knows that the right of inheritance gives you, above every other man, the claim to take his daughter. Hear me now, brother: this night we will talk about the girl and arrange your betrothal to her, and on our return from Rages we will receive her and lead her home with us to your house." 14 Then Tobias answered Raphael, "Brother Azariah, I am told she has been married seven times over, and each of those husbands perished in the bridal room; the very night he went in to her, he died. People say, I have heard, that some demon was their killer. 15 So now I am afraid. It does her no harm, but anyone who tries to come near her, it kills. I am my father's only son. I fear I will die and bring my father's and my mother's life down to their grave in sorrow over me; and they have no other son to bury them." 16 But Raphael said to him, "Have you forgotten the instructions of your father, who charged you to marry a woman from your father's house? So now listen to me, brother: pay

no attention to this demon, but take her. I know that before this night
is over she will become your wife. 17 Once you enter the bridal room,
take a portion of the liver of the fish, along with the heart, and set
them on the embers of the incense. The odor will spread; the demon
will catch the smell and run away, and it will never again be seen near
her for all time. 18 And before you are to be united with her, both of
you must first rise and pray, and implore the Lord of heaven to grant
you mercy and deliverance. Have no fear; she was destined for you
from eternity. It is you who will rescue her, and she will go away with
you; I expect, too, that she will bear you children, who will be as dear
to you as brothers. Do not worry." 19 When Tobias heard Raphael's
words, and learned that she was his kinswoman,[e] of the lineage of his
father's house, he loved her deeply, and his heart clung to her.

Notes

- a (6:1) The dog came out with him: Sinaiticus mentions the dog only here and at 11:4; GI places it at 5:16. Dogs are seldom viewed favorably in the Bible, and the detail is unusual.
- b (6:10) Approaching Ecbatana: GI reads "as they came near to Rages," evidently in error, since Raguel lived at Ecbatana (3:7).
- c (6:12) Nearest kinsman with the right to marry her: Greek "nearest to her to inherit her." Compare the laws on heiresses marrying within their father's tribe (Numbers 27:1–11; 36:1–12).
- d (6:13) The penalty of death under the ruling of the book of Moses: no such penalty appears in the law of Moses; the statement may reflect a later interpretation, and its basis is uncertain. Scholarly review recommended.
- e (6:19) Kinswoman: Greek "sister," here a relative of his own clan. GI reads simply "when Tobias heard these things, he loved her."

Chapter 7

1 When he reached Ecbatana, he said to him, "Brother Azariah, take
me straight to our kinsman Raguel." So he brought him to Raguel's
house, and they found the man seated beside the gate of the court-
yard. They were the first to greet him, and he answered them, "Joy
and greetings to you, brothers! You are welcome here, and safe and
sound." And he led them into his house. 2 He said to Edna[a] his wife,
"How much this young fellow looks like my kinsman Tobit!" 3 Edna
questioned them: "Where do you come from, brothers?" They told

her, “We belong to the descendants of Naphtali, who were taken captive to Nineveh.” 4 She asked them, “Do you know our kinsman Tobit?” They said to her, “We do know him.” 5 She asked them, “Is he well?” They replied, “He is alive and well.” And Tobias added, “He is my father.” 6 At that Raguel leaped to his feet, kissed him, and wept. Then he spoke to him: “A blessing on you, my boy, son of a fine and noble father! Oh, what a wretched misfortune, that a man so righteous, so generous in charity, should have gone blind!” And he threw his arms around the neck of his kinsman Tobias and wept. 7 Edna his wife wept for Tobit, and Sarah their daughter wept as well. 8 Raguel then killed a ram from his sheep and received them with eager hospitality.

9 After they had bathed and washed and reclined to dine, Tobias said to Raphael, “Brother Azariah, speak to Raguel, so that he will give me Sarah my kinswoman.” 10 Raguel overheard the words and said to the young man, “Eat and drink and enjoy yourself tonight. For there is no man except you, brother, who has the right to take my daughter Sarah; and likewise I have no authority to give her to anyone but you, since you are my nearest relative. But I must tell you the truth plainly, my boy. 11 Seven men of our kindred have received her from me in marriage, and each died the night he went in to her. But now, my boy, eat and drink; the Lord will deal kindly with you both.” 12 But Tobias said, “I will eat nothing here, and drink nothing, until you settle my affair.” Raguel said to him, “I will. She is yours by the ruling of the book of Moses, and heaven itself has decreed that she is to be yours. Receive your kinswoman. You are her brother from this moment, and she is your sister.[b] From today and for all time she belongs to you. My child, may the Lord of heaven grant you success this night, and may he show you mercy and peace.” 13 Then Raguel called for Sarah his daughter. She came, and taking her hand, he gave her over to Tobias with the words, “Receive her, in keeping with the law and with the ruling recorded in the book of Moses that grants her to you as a wife. Keep her, and bring her home unharmed to your father; the God of heaven grant you a prosperous journey in peace.” 14 Then he called for her mother and told her to fetch a scroll, and he wrote out a marriage

contract,[c] stating that he gave her to Tobias as his wife under the terms of the law of Moses. After that they started to eat and drink.
15 Raguel called his wife Edna and told her, "My sister, get the second
bedroom ready, and bring her into it." 16 She went and spread the bed
in that room, just as he had said, and led Sarah in. She wept over her;
then, wiping away her tears, she said to her, 17 "Courage, daughter!
The Lord of heaven grant you gladness instead of grief. Courage,
daughter!" And she went out.

Notes

- a (7:2) Edna: from Hebrew ʿednah, "pleasure, delight."
- b (7:12) Her brother … your sister: terms of endearment used of husband and wife (compare Song of Songs 4:9–10), here also implying kinship.
- c (7:14) Marriage contract: Greek "a written record of cohabitation"; this is among the earliest references in Jewish literature to a written marriage contract (compare the later ketubbah). GI adds that "they set their seals to it."

Chapter 8

1 Once the eating and drinking were over, they were ready to go to
bed; so they led the young man away and took him into the bridal
room. 2 Tobias called to mind what Raphael had said. Taking the liver
and the heart of the fish from the bag he carried, he laid them on the
embers of the incense. 3 The smell of the fish held the demon back,[a]
and it fled off to the regions of upper Egypt.[b] Raphael went after it,
and there he bound it hand and foot and fettered it at once. 4 The
others went out and shut the door of the bedroom. Then Tobias got
up from the bed and said to her, "Get up, my sister; let us pray and
ask our Lord to show us mercy and grant us deliverance." 5 She rose,
and the two of them started praying, pleading that they might be
kept safe. He began with these words: "You are blessed, God of our
fathers, and your name is blessed through all the ages to come! Let
the heavens and your whole creation bless you through all the ages.
6 It was you who made Adam, and you made Eve his wife to be his
helper and support; the two of them are the source of all humankind.
You declared, 'It is not good that the man should be by himself; let us
make a helper for him who corresponds to him.'[c] 7 And now, it is not
out of lust[d] that I am taking this kinswoman of mine, but in sincerity.

Command that mercy be shown to her and to me, and that we may
grow old side by side." [8] And together they said, "Amen, amen." [9] Then
they slept through the night.
[10] But Raguel rose and called his servants to him, and they went out
and dug a grave, for he said, "He may die, and then we would become
a laughingstock and a byword." [11] Once the grave was dug, Raguel
returned to the house and summoned his wife, [12] saying, "Send one of
the maids to go in and see whether he is alive. If he is dead, we can
bury him without anyone knowing." [13] So they sent the maid, lit the
lamp, and opened the door. She went in and found the two of them
sound asleep together. [14] The maid came out and told them that he
was alive and that nothing bad had happened. [15] Then they blessed
the God of heaven and said, "Blessed are you, O God, with every pure
blessing; let them bless you through all the ages. [16] Blessed are you,
because you have made me glad; what I feared has not come to pass,
but you have dealt with us according to your great mercy. [17] Blessed
are you, because you have had mercy on two only children. Show
them mercy, Master, and deliverance; bring their lives to completion
in gladness and mercy." [18] After that he told his servants to shovel the
earth back into the grave before dawn came.
[19] He told his wife to bake a great many loaves; and going out to the
herd, he brought back two oxen and four rams and ordered them
slaughtered, and they began to prepare the feast. [20] Then he called
Tobias and said to him, "For fourteen days you are not to stir from
here. Stay right here, eating and drinking with me, and cheer the
heart of my daughter, who has suffered so much. [21] Take half of all I
own here and now, and return to your father unharmed; the remain-
ing half is yours when my wife and I are dead. Be of good heart, my
child! From now on I am a father to you, and Edna a mother; we are
yours, and your sister's,[e] from now and forever. Be of good heart,
my child!"

Notes

- a (8:3) Held the demon back: or "checked" or "repelled"; the Greek verb is unusual here. GI reads "When the demon smelled the odor."

- b (8:3) Upper Egypt: Egypt was traditionally regarded as a home of magic and of demons. GI reads "the remotest parts of Egypt, and the angel bound him."
- c (8:6) It is not good for the man to be alone: Genesis 2:18.
- d (8:7) Lust: Greek porneia, "sexual immorality," here desire without regard to God's law.
- e (8:21) Your sister: that is, Sarah, his wife.

Chapter 9

1 Then Tobias called Raphael and said to him, 2 "Brother Azariah, take
along four of the servants and a pair of camels and go to Rages. Visit
Gabael, hand him the bond, collect the silver, and bring him back
with you to the wedding celebration. 3 You are aware that my father
must be reckoning the days, and should I be one day overdue, I would
grieve him sorely;[a] 4 and you see what Raguel has sworn, and I cannot
break his oath." 5 So Raphael, with the four servants and the two
camels, made the journey to Rages in Media, and they lodged with
Gabael. Raphael gave him his bond and explained to him that Tobias
son of Tobit had taken a wife and was inviting him to the wedding
celebration. Gabael rose and counted out the bags to him, their seals
intact, and they loaded them together. 6 Early in the morning they
all set out together and came to the wedding feast. Entering Raguel's
home, they found Tobias at table. He leaped up and embraced Gabael,
and Gabael burst into tears and blessed him, saying, "Good and noble
son of a good and noble man, righteous and generous in charity! May
the Lord grant heaven's blessing to you and your wife, to your father,
and to your wife's mother. Blessed be God, for I have seen my cousin
Tobit's very likeness!"[b]

Notes

- a (9:3) Distress: Sinaiticus runs verses 3 and 4 together (Rahlfs prints them as "3–4"); they are divided here according to the usual numbering. GI lacks both verses, and in verse 2 has "take a servant" rather than four.
- b (9:6) My cousin Tobit's very likeness: Greek "Tobit my cousin, like him," meaning that Tobias resembles his father. GI omits the whole of Gabael's speech, reading only "and Tobias blessed his wife."

Chapter 10

1 Meanwhile, day after day, Tobit kept counting the days: how many
it would take Tobias to get there and how many to come back. When
the days had run out and his son had not appeared, 2 he said, "Could
he have been held up there? Or could Gabael be dead, with nobody
left to pay him the silver?" 3 And he began to be anxious. 4 His wife
Anna kept saying, "My child has perished; he is no longer among the
living." She began to weep and wail over her son, and she said, 5 "Alas
for me, my child! Why did I allow you to go, light of my eyes?"[a] 6
But Tobit kept saying to her, "Hush, do not worry, my sister; he is
well. No doubt something has come up to keep them busy there. His
companion is a man to be trusted, a kinsman of ours. Stop grieving
over him, my sister; he will soon be back." 7 She answered him, "Hush
yourself, and do not try to deceive me. My child has perished." And
she would rush out and watch the road her son had taken, every day,
and would believe no one. When the sun went down, she would go
inside and lament and weep all night long, without any sleep.[b]
8 When the fourteen days of wedding festivities that Raguel had
vowed to hold for his daughter were finished, Tobias came to him and
said, "Send me off, because I know my father and mother no longer
expect to see me again. So now, father, I ask you to let me leave, so
that I can go back to my father. I have already told you how I left
him." 9 Raguel urged Tobias, "Stay, child, stay here with me. I will
dispatch messengers to Tobit your father, who will tell him how you
are." But Tobias said, "By no means. I beg you to send me back from
here to my father." 10 Then Raguel rose and handed over to Tobias his
wife Sarah, together with a half share of all his goods: menservants
and maidservants, cattle and flocks, donkeys and camels, garments,
silver, and household utensils. 11 He sent them away in good health.
He embraced Tobias and said to him, "Farewell, my child; go in health.
May the Lord of heaven make the way prosperous for you and for
Sarah your wife, and may I see children of yours before I die." 12 And
he said to his daughter Sarah, "Go to your father-in-law's house, for
from now on they are your parents as much as those who gave you
birth. Go in peace, daughter. May I hear good reports of you as long as

I live." Then he kissed them good-bye and sent them off. 13 And Edna said to Tobias, "My son and beloved brother, may the Lord restore you safely, and may I live to see children born to you and to my daughter Sarah before my death. In the presence of the Lord I am entrusting my daughter to your keeping. Never cause her sorrow as long as you live. Go in peace, my son. Henceforth I am a mother to you, and Sarah a sister.[c] May every one of us prosper alike, every day that we live." And she kissed them both and sent them off in good health. 14 So Tobias left Raguel's house in health and joy, blessing the Lord of heaven and earth, King over all things, because he had prospered his way. And he said to him,[d] "It has been granted you to honor them all the days of their life."

Notes

- a (10:5) The light of my eyes: GI reads "I do not care about anything, my child, since I let you go, the light of my eyes."
- b (10:7) Without any sleep: GI is shorter in verses 6–7 and adds that she would not eat during the day and did not stop lamenting her son Tobias until the fourteen days of the wedding were over.
- c (10:13) A sister: here, a relative by marriage.
- d (10:14) He said to him: the Greek of Sinaiticus is apparently damaged here; the sense may be a blessing spoken to Tobias, that he would have the privilege of honoring his parents-in-law ("them") as long as they lived. GI reads "and he blessed Raguel and Edna his wife." Scholarly review recommended.

Chapter 11

1 As they drew near to Kaserin,[a] which lies opposite Nineveh, Raphael said, 2 "You know the condition in which we left your father. 3 Let us rush ahead of your wife and get the house ready while the others are still traveling." 4 So the two of them went on together. And Raphael said to him, "Keep the gall ready in your hand." And the dog trotted along at their heels, behind Raphael and Tobias.[b]

5 Anna, meanwhile, sat watching the road by which her son would come. 6 She spied him on his way and called to his father, "See, here comes your son, along with the man who went with him!" 7 Before Tobias came up to his father, Raphael told him, "I am sure that his eyes will be opened. 8 Rub the gall of the fish onto his eyes; the medicine will contract the white films and strip them from his eyes, and your

father will look up and behold the light." [9] Anna ran up and threw
her arms around her son's neck, saying to him, "I have seen you, my
child! Now I can die." And she wept. [10] Tobit got up and, stumbling as
he went, made his way out through the courtyard door. [11] Tobias went
up to him with the fish's gall in his hand. He blew into his eyes, took
hold of him, and said, "Be brave, father!" Then he applied the remedy
to him and left it on for a while.[c] [12] Next, using both hands, he peeled
the films away from the corners of his eyes. [13] Tobit threw his arms
around his neck and wept, and said to him, "I can see you, my son,
the light of my eyes!" [14] And he said, "Blessed is God, and blessed his
great name, and blessed all his holy angels! May his great name rest
upon us,[d] and blessed be all the angels to all the ages. For he afflicted
me with the scourge, yet now I behold my son Tobias!" [15] Tobias went
in rejoicing and blessing God aloud with his whole voice. He told his
father that his journey had prospered, that he had brought back the
silver, and how he had married Sarah, Raguel's daughter, and that she
was even now on her way and close to the gate of Nineveh.
[16] Then Tobit went out toward the gate of Nineveh, rejoicing and
praising God, to welcome his son's bride. The people of Nineveh,
watching him walk with all his vigor and no one guiding him by
the hand, were astonished. And Tobit declared in front of them that
God had been merciful to him and had opened his eyes. [17] When
Tobit reached Sarah, his son Tobias's wife, he blessed her and said,
"Welcome, daughter, and good health to you! Blessed is your God for
bringing you to us, daughter; blessed is your father, blessed is my
son Tobias, and blessed are you, daughter. Come into your home in
good health, with blessing and joy; come in, daughter." [18] On that day
joy came to every Jew living in Nineveh. [19] And Ahikar and Nadab,[e]
Tobit's nephews, came to him full of joy.

Notes

- a (11:1) Kaserin: an otherwise unknown place; the name may be corrupt. GI reads simply "until they came near to Nineveh."
- b (11:4) Behind Raphael and Tobias: the Greek of Sinaiticus is awkward here ("behind him, and Tobias"). GI places the dog "behind them" and puts the command about the gall before the departure.

- c (11:11) Left it on for a while: the sense of the Greek verb (epedōken) is uncertain. GI describes the treatment differently: Tobias sprinkled the gall on his father's eyes, and when they smarted, Tobit rubbed them and the films scaled off.
- d (11:14) Rest upon us: literally "be upon us." GI reads more briefly: "Blessed are you, O God, and blessed is your name forever, and blessed are all your holy angels; for you scourged me and had mercy on me."
- e (11:19) Ahikar and Nadab: on Ahikar see the note at 1:21. GI reads "Achiacharus and Nasbas his nephew," and adds that Tobias's wedding was celebrated with gladness for seven days.

Chapter 12

1 When the wedding celebration was over, Tobit called his son Tobias
and said to him, "My child, see to it that you pay the man who went
with you his wages, and give him something more besides." 2 Tobias
answered him, "Father, how much shall I pay him? It would be no loss
to me to give him half of the goods he brought back with me. 3 He has
led me back safe and sound; he cured my wife; he brought the silver
back with me; and he cured you too. How much more should I pay
him as wages?" 4 Tobit said to him, "It is only right, my child, that he
should receive half of everything he brought back." 5 So Tobias called
him and said, "Take as your wages half of everything you brought
back, and go in health."
6 Then Raphael called the two of them aside in secret and told them,
"Bless God, and in the sight of all who live acknowledge the kindness
he has shown you, so that they may bless and sing praise to his
name. Make known to all people the words of God, as is fitting,
and do not hesitate to give him thanks. 7 It is right to keep a king's
secret, but the works of God are to be revealed and acknowledged
with honor. Do what is good, and evil will not overtake you. 8 Prayer
with truthfulness is good, and charity with righteousness, better than
wealth with wrongdoing. Better to give charity than to hoard gold.[a] 9
Charity rescues from death, and it purges away every sin. Those who
give charity will have their fill of life. 10 Those who commit sin and
wrongdoing are enemies of their own selves.
11 "I will disclose the whole truth to you and will keep nothing hidden
from you. I have already declared it to you, saying, 'It is right to keep
a king's secret, but the works of God are to be revealed with glory.'

12 Now then: when you prayed, you and Sarah, I was the one who
carried the memorial of your prayer[b] into the presence of the Lord's
glory; and I did the same each time you gave burial to the dead. 13
And when you did not hesitate to get up and leave your meal and
went and laid out the dead man, then I was sent to you to test you.[c]
14 And God has sent me at the same time to bring healing to you and
to Sarah, your son's wife. 15 I am Raphael, one of seven angels who
attend and go in before the Lord's glory."[d]
16 The two of them were shaken; they fell on their faces in fear. 17 But
he told them, "Have no fear; peace to you. Bless God for all time. 18 As
for me, when I was with you, I was not with you by any favor of my
own, but by the will of God. Bless him every day; sing his praise. 19 You
watched me, but I ate nothing; what you saw was a vision.[e] 20 So now
bless the Lord here on earth and thank God. See, I am ascending to
the one who sent me. Record everything that has happened to you."
And he ascended. 21 They rose to their feet, but he was no longer to be
seen. 22 They kept blessing God and singing hymns to him, and they
gave thanks to him for these great works of his, that an angel of God
had appeared to them.

Notes

- a (12:8) Better to give charity than to hoard gold: GI reads "Prayer is good with fasting and charity and righteousness. A little with righteousness is better than much with wrongdoing."
- b (12:12) The record of your prayer: Greek mnēmosynon, "memorial," a term used of offerings that bring something to God's remembrance (compare Leviticus 2:2; Acts 10:4).
- c (12:13) To test you: GI reads instead "your good deed did not escape me; I was with you."
- d (12:15) Seven angels: compare Revelation 8:2. GI describes Raphael as one of the seven holy angels who carry the prayers of the saints and go in before the glory of the Holy One. On the meaning of Raphael's name see the note at 1:1.
- e (12:19) A vision: that is, an appearance only. GI reads "All these days I merely appeared to you; I did not eat or drink, but you were seeing a vision."

Chapter 13

1 Then Tobit said:[a]

2 “Blessed is God, the ever-living,
and blessed his reign!
For he chastises, and he shows mercy;
he brings down to Hades, to the lowest depths of the earth,
and he himself brings up from the great destruction;
there is nothing that can slip from his hand.
3 Give him thanks, you children of Israel, in the sight of the nations,
for he himself has scattered you among them,
4 and there he has displayed his majesty to you.
Exalt him in the presence of all that lives,
for it is he who is Lord to us, he who is God to us;
he is Father to us, and God for all the ages.
5 He will chastise you for your wrongdoing,
and he will have mercy on all of you
and gather you out of all the nations
wherever you have been scattered among them.[b]
6 Once you return to him wholeheartedly, with your entire soul,
to practice faithfulness before him,
he too will return to you
and no longer conceal his face from you.
7 Look now at all he has done with you,
and praise him aloud with your whole mouth.
Bless the Lord of righteousness,
and lift high the King of the ages.
8 Here, in the country of my captivity, I praise him;
I proclaim his might and his majesty to a sinful people.[c]
Return, sinners, and act righteously in his sight;
who can tell? He may take pleasure in you and deal kindly with you.
9 I extol my God;
my soul extols heaven’s King
and will exult in his majesty.
10 Let everyone declare it and praise him in Jerusalem.
Jerusalem, city of holiness,

he will chastise you for the deeds of your children,
yet once more he will show compassion to the offspring of the just.
11 And once more your tent will be rebuilt for you with joy.[d]
12 May he bring gladness within you to every captive,
and cherish within you all who are wretched,
to all generations forever.
13 A brilliant light will blaze to all the earth's limits;
from afar a multitude of nations will come to you,
and the dwellers at the world's remotest edges to your holy name,
carrying gifts in their hands for heaven's King.
Age upon age will give exultation within you,
and the name of the elect city will last for every age to come.
14 A curse on all who speak harshly of you!
Accursed will be all who tear you down and pull down your walls,
all who overturn your towers and set fire to your dwellings;
but blessed forever will be all who revere you.
15 Then go and exult among the offspring of the just,
since every one of them will be assembled to bless the eternal Lord.
How fortunate are your lovers!
How fortunate those whose joy will be in your peace!
16 Fortunate as well are all who mourned for you
because of every blow you bore;
for in you they will find joy,
and they will look on the fullness of your gladness forever.
Bless the Lord, my soul, the mighty King!
17 For Jerusalem will be rebuilt as a city,[e] his house for all the ages.
I will be happy if a remnant of my descendants survives
to look on your splendor and praise heaven's King.
Of sapphire and emerald Jerusalem's gates will be made,
and of costly stone every wall of yours;
of gold Jerusalem's towers will be constructed,
their ramparts of refined gold.
Jerusalem's squares will be laid with garnet[f] and Ophir stone.[g]
18 Jerusalem's gateways will ring with songs of gladness,
and every house in her will shout, 'Hallelujah!

Israel's God be blessed!'

And those he has blessed will praise his holy name for all time and beyond."

Notes

- a (13:1) Then Tobit said: GI reads "Then Tobit wrote a prayer of rejoicing and said."
- b (13:5) Scattered among them: Sinaiticus reads "and he will have mercy on all of you from all the nations wherever you have been scattered among them"; the words "and gather you" are supplied from GI to complete the sense.
- c (13:8) To a nation of sinners: verses 8–10 are missing from Sinaiticus, apparently through a scribe's eye skipping a line, and are translated here from GI (Vaticanus). Small Qumran fragments of this hymn are reported (4Q198–200), but they do not cover the whole gap. Scholarly review recommended.
- d (13:11) Your tent: that is, the Temple, pictured as God's dwelling-tent.
- e (13:17) Rebuilt as a city: the Greek of Sinaiticus is awkward (literally "will be built for the city"); GI reads simply "Jerusalem will be built."
- f (13:17) Garnet: Greek anthrax, a deep-red precious stone (perhaps carbuncle or ruby). GI adds beryl.
- g (13:17) Ophir: Greek Souphir, a form of Ophir, the land famous for its gold (1 Kings 9:28).

Chapter 14

1 So ended the words of Tobit's song of praise.[a] 2 Tobit died in peace at the age of one hundred twelve and was buried with honor in Nineveh. He had been sixty-two years old when he lost the use of his eyes, and after his sight returned he lived in prosperity, giving charity and continuing to bless God and to proclaim God's majesty.[b]

3 As he lay dying, he summoned his son Tobias and gave him these instructions: "My child, take your children away 4 and hurry off to Media, for I put my trust in the word God spoke through Nahum[c] concerning Nineveh, that it will all come true and will overtake Assyria and Nineveh. Whatever the prophets of Israel whom God sent have spoken, all of it will happen; not one of their words will fall short, and everything will come about at its proper time. There will be more safety in Media than in Assyria or Babylon. For I know and trust that everything God has said will be carried out and will come to pass; not one word of his sayings will fail. Our kindred who live in the land of Israel will all be dispersed and carried off as captives from

that good land. The whole land of Israel will become a wasteland;
Samaria and Jerusalem will be a wasteland, and God's house will
be in mourning and will lie burned for a time. 5 Yet God will once
more show them mercy and restore them to Israel's land. Again they
will build the house, though it will not equal the former one, until
the period of the appointed ages is fulfilled. After that they will all
return from their captivity and rebuild Jerusalem in splendor, and in
her God's house will be built anew,[d] in keeping with what Israel's
prophets have foretold about her. 6 Then all the nations throughout
the whole earth will turn and fear God in truth. Every one of them
will abandon the idols that have deceived them into falsehood, and
they will bless the everlasting God in righteousness. 7 All the children
of Israel who are rescued in those days, who remember God faith-
fully, will be assembled and make their way to Jerusalem, and dwell
securely in the land of Abraham forever, and it will be handed over
to them. Whoever loves God in sincerity will be glad, but those who
practice sin and wrongdoing will vanish from all the earth.[e]
8 "And now, my children, I charge you: serve God faithfully and
do what pleases him. Your children are to be instructed to practice
righteousness and charity, to keep God in mind, and to bless his name
at every season, faithfully and with all their strength.[f] 9 And now
you, my child, leave Nineveh; do not stay on here. On the day you
bury your mother beside me, do not spend that very night within the
city's limits. For I can see that there is much wickedness in it, and
great treachery is carried on there, and the people have no shame. 10
Consider, my child, all that Nadab did to Ahikar, who had brought
him up. Was not Ahikar sent down alive into the earth?[g] But God
paid back the disgrace to Nadab's face: Ahikar came out into the light,
while Nadab went into the everlasting darkness, because he had tried
to kill Ahikar. Because Ahikar gave charity, he escaped the deadly
trap that Nadab had set for him, but Nadab himself fell into the deadly
trap, and it destroyed him.[h] 11 So now, my children, see what charity
accomplishes, and what wrongdoing accomplishes: it brings death.
But now my breath is failing me." They placed him upon his couch,
and he breathed his last; and they gave him an honorable burial.[i]

12 After his mother's death, Tobias laid her in the tomb with his father.
Then, with his wife, he departed for Media and made his home at
Ecbatana alongside Raguel, the father of his wife. 13 He looked after
them in their old age with every respect and buried them at Ecbatana
in Media, and he inherited the household of Raguel as well as that
of his father Tobit. 14 He died with honor at the age of one hundred
seventeen.[j] 15 Before his own death he witnessed and was told of the
ruin of Nineveh, and he watched its prisoners being marched off to
Media, those whom Cyaxares[k] king of Media had taken captive. He
praised God for everything he had brought upon the inhabitants of
Nineveh and Assyria. While still alive he exulted over Nineveh's fate,
and he blessed the Lord God for all ages upon ages.

Notes

- a (14:1) Song of praise: Greek exomologēsis, "thanksgiving" or "confession," referring to the hymn of chapter 13.
- b (14:2) Majesty: GI gives different figures: Tobit was fifty-eight years old when he lost his sight, and he regained it eight years later. GI also omits his age at death here, giving it instead in verse 11 (one hundred fifty-eight years).
- c (14:4) Nahum: the prophet whose book foretells the fall of Nineveh (612 BC). GI reads "Jonah," whose preaching announced Nineveh's overthrow (Jonah 3:4). Some later manuscripts of GI also read "Nahum."
- d (14:5) Will be rebuilt: GI adds "for all generations forever, with a glorious building." Tobit's words look ahead to the modest Second Temple (compare Ezra 3:12; Haggai 2:3) and then to a glorious final restoration.
- e (14:7) Vanish from all the earth: GI's verse 7 is quite different. It says that his people will give thanks to God, that the Lord will lift up his people, and that all who truly love the Lord God and are righteous will rejoice and show mercy to their kindred.
- f (14:8) All their strength: Sinaiticus runs verses 8 and 9 together (Rahlfs prints them as "8–9"); they are divided here according to the usual numbering. GI lacks this exhortation.
- g (14:10) Sent down alive into the earth: in the Story of Ahikar (see the note at 1:21), Ahikar, falsely accused by his adopted son Nadab, was hidden alive in an underground chamber until he could be vindicated. GI names the nephew "Aman" instead of Nadab.
- h (14:10) Destroyed him: GI says that "Manasseh" (apparently a corruption of the name of Ahikar) gave charity and was rescued.
- i (14:11) Buried with honor: GI adds that he was one hundred fifty-eight years old.

- j (14:14) One hundred seventeen: GI reads “one hundred twenty-seven years, in Ecbatana of Media.”
- k (14:15) Cyaxares: Greek Achiacharos, king of the Medes (about 625–585 BC), who with the Babylonian Nabopolassar destroyed Nineveh in 612 BC. GI reads “Nebuchadnezzar and Ahasuerus.” Neither manuscript tradition matches the historical record precisely; scholarly review recommended.

Judith

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 It was the twelfth year of the reign of Nebuchadnezzar,[a] king of
Assyria, whose seat was Nineveh, that mighty city. In those days
Arphaxad[b] reigned over the Medes in Ecbatana.[c] 2 Around Ecbatana
he built walls of hewn stones, each stone about four and a half feet
thick and nine feet long.[d] He made the wall about a hundred five feet
high and seventy-five feet thick. 3 At its gates he set up towers about
a hundred fifty feet high, laying their foundations ninety feet wide. 4
He made its gates tall enough to rise about a hundred five feet, and
sixty feet wide, so that his mighty army could march out through
them and his infantry could parade in formation. 5 In those days
King Nebuchadnezzar waged war against King Arphaxad in the great
plain, the plain that lies within the borders of Ragau.[e] 6 Rallying to
Arphaxad's side[f] came all the hill-dwellers, the peoples on the banks
of the Euphrates, Tigris and Hydaspes,[g] and those of the plains ruled
by Arioch king of the Elymaeans.[h] Many nations joined forces with
the people of Cheleoud.[i]
7 Then Nebuchadnezzar king of the Assyrians dispatched messengers
to every inhabitant of Persia and to every western people: to the
inhabitants of Cilicia, of Damascus, of Lebanon and the Antilebanon,
and of the whole seaboard, 8 to those among the nations of Carmel and
Gilead, upper Galilee and the great plain of Esdraelon,[j] 9 to everyone
in Samaria and the towns around it, to the land across the Jordan up
to Jerusalem, Betane, Chelous and Kadesh, and the River of Egypt,[k] to
Tahpanhes and Raamses, and throughout the land of Goshen, 10 even
beyond Tanis and Memphis, and to every inhabitant of Egypt up to
Ethiopia's frontier. 11 But the inhabitants of that entire region scorned
the order of Assyria's king Nebuchadnezzar and refused to go to war

at his side. They had no fear of him; to them he was no more than a single man. They sent his envoys back empty-handed and in disgrace.
12 Nebuchadnezzar's anger blazed fiercely against all that land, and he took an oath by his throne and his royal power to avenge himself on all the territory of Cilicia, Damascus and Syria, and would slay with his sword the inhabitants of Moab, the Ammonites, all of Judea, and every soul in Egypt, up to the shores of the two seas.[l] 13 In the seventeenth year he drew up his forces against King Arphaxad and overpowered him in battle. He routed Arphaxad's entire army, all his cavalry and all his chariots. 14 He took possession of his cities and went on as far as Ecbatana. He seized its towers, plundered its marketplaces, and turned its splendor into shame. 15 He captured Arphaxad in the mountains of Ragau, ran him through with his spears, and finished him off once and for all. 16 Then he returned to Nineveh with his spoil, he and his whole combined army, an immense multitude of fighting men; and there he and his army took their ease and feasted for one hundred twenty days.

Notes

- a (1:1) Nebuchadnezzar: Nebuchadnezzar II (reigned 605–562 BC) was in fact king of Babylon, not of Assyria, and Nineveh had been destroyed in 612 BC, before his reign began (see 2:28 and 5:18–19, where the return from exile is already past). The book's combination of historical names from different periods is widely understood as deliberate: the story gathers the great enemies of Israel into a single figure, and the opening signals to the reader that this is an exemplary tale rather than a chronicle. Scholarly review recommended.
- b (1:1) Arphaxad: not known from other sources. Suggested identifications (for example Phraortes, king of the Medes, about 675–653 BC, or Deioces, the founder of Ecbatana) are reported but uncertain.
- c (1:1) Ecbatana: the Median capital, modern Hamadan in western Iran.
- d (1:2) About four and a half feet thick and nine feet long: literally "three cubits in breadth and six cubits in length." A cubit, the length from the elbow to the fingertip, was about 18 inches (45 cm), so the stones were about 1.4 m by 2.7 m. In verses 2–4, the wall was 70 cubits high (about 32 m) and 50 cubits thick (about 23 m); the towers were 100 cubits high (about 45 m) on foundations 60 cubits wide (about 27 m); and the gates were 70 cubits high (about 32 m) and 40 cubits wide (about 18 m). The dimensions are deliberately vast.
- e (1:5) Ragau: the same as Rages in Tobit (Rhagae), southeast of modern Tehran.

- f (1:6) Rallying to Arphaxad's side: literally "there came together to him"; the Greek may also be read as gathering to Nebuchadnezzar.
- g (1:6) Hydaspes: a river in northwestern India (the Jhelum), far from the scene; the name may be a corruption of another river name, possibly the Choaspes near Susa.
- h (1:6) Elymaeans: the people of Elam, east of the lower Tigris.
- i (1:6) Cheleoud: unidentified; some identify it with the Chaldeans. Scholarly review recommended.
- j (1:8) Esdraelon: the Greek form of Jezreel, the broad valley between Galilee and Samaria.
- k (1:9) The River of Egypt: the Wadi el-Arish in northern Sinai, the traditional southern border of Canaan.
- l (1:12) The two seas: perhaps the Mediterranean and the Red Sea (or the Persian Gulf).

Chapter 2

1 In year eighteen, on the first month's twenty-second day (March–April),[a] word went forth in the house of Nebuchadnezzar, Assyria's king, that he would take vengeance on all the earth, as he had declared. 2 He summoned all his officials and all his nobles, laid before them his secret plan, and with his own lips pronounced utter ruin upon the region. 3 They resolved to destroy everyone who had not heeded the command of his mouth. 4 His plan complete, Nebuchadnezzar king of Assyria sent for Holofernes,[b] supreme commander of his forces and next in rank to the king, and told him, 5 "Thus says the great king, the lord of the whole earth: Go out from my presence, and take with you men who trust in their own strength, one hundred twenty thousand foot soldiers and a force of twelve thousand horses with their riders. 6 March out against the whole land to the west, because they disobeyed the command of my mouth. 7 Order them to prepare earth and water,[c] because I am coming out against them in my fury and will cover the whole face of the earth with the feet of my army, and I will hand them over to my troops to plunder. 8 Their wounded will fill their ravines, and every stream and river will overflow, choked with their dead. 9 Their captives I will carry off to the farthest limits of all the earth. 10 Go, then, and seize all their territory for me in advance. If they surrender to you, you are to hold them for me until the day of their punishment. 11 But as for those who

resist, show them no pity; hand them over to slaughter and plunder throughout your whole territory. 12 For as I live, and by the power of my kingdom, I have spoken, and I will accomplish this by my own hand. 13 And you, do not transgress a single one of your lord's commands, but carry them out to the letter, just as I have ordered you, and do not delay in doing them."
14 So Holofernes went out from the presence of his lord and summoned all the princes, generals and officers of the Assyrian army. 15 He mustered picked men for battle, as his lord had ordered him, one hundred twenty thousand of them, with twelve thousand mounted archers, 16 and he organized them as a great army is marshaled for war. 17 He took along a huge number of camels, donkeys and mules to carry their baggage, and sheep, oxen and goats beyond counting for their provisions, 18 as well as ample rations for every man, and a great quantity of gold and silver from the royal treasury. 19 Then he and his entire force took the road, to march in advance of King Nebuchadnezzar and to blanket the whole western face of the earth with their chariots, horsemen and choice foot soldiers. 20 A vast motley crowd came out with them, as numerous as locusts or as the sand of the earth, for their multitude was beyond counting.
21 They marched three days out of Nineveh to the edge of the plain of Bectileth,[d] and from Bectileth they made camp near the mountain that lies to the north[e] of upper Cilicia. 22 From there he took his whole force, foot soldiers, horsemen and chariots, and moved off into the highlands. 23 He cut his way through Put and Lud[f] and pillaged every one of the people of Rassis and the Ishmaelites who lived along the edge of the desert, south of the land of the Cheleans. 24 Then he crossed the Euphrates, passed through Mesopotamia, and demolished every walled town by the Wadi Abron,[g] all the way to the sea. 25 He seized the territory of Cilicia, cut down all who opposed him, and came to the borders of Japheth, which face Arabia to the south. 26 He surrounded all the Midianites, set fire to their tents, and looted their sheepfolds. 27 Descending into the Damascus plain while the wheat was being harvested, he set all their fields on fire, wiped out their

flocks and herds, sacked their towns, laid waste their plains,[h] and cut down all their youths with the edge of the sword.
28 Terror and dread of him overwhelmed everyone along the coast, the people of Sidon and Tyre, the inhabitants of Sur and Ocina, and everyone in Jamnia. The people of Azotus and Ashkelon were frightened of him.[i]

Notes

- a (2:1) First month (March–April): the month Nisan, the first month of the spring new year.
- b (2:4) Holofernes: a Persian name (compare Orophernes, a Cappadocian prince of the 2nd century BC, and a Persian general of the 4th century BC named in Diodorus, as reported). Its use for an Assyrian commander is another sign of the book's blending of periods.
- c (2:7) Earth and water: the traditional Persian demand for tokens of submission (Herodotus, Histories 6.48).
- d (2:21) Bectileth: an unknown location; three days' march from Nineveh would not reach Cilicia, and the geography of the campaign is schematic.
- e (2:21) To the north: Greek "on the left," facing east.
- f (2:23) Put and Lud: peoples usually placed in Africa and Asia Minor (Genesis 10:6, 13, 22); here the names seem to be used freely. Rassis is unidentified (perhaps Rhosus in Cilicia, or Tarsus); the Cheleans are perhaps the Chaldeans or the people of Chaluus.
- g (2:24) Wadi Abron: unidentified; perhaps the Habor (Khabur), a tributary of the Euphrates, or a corruption of "Hebrews."
- h (2:27) Laid waste their plains: literally "winnowed their plains," scattering them like chaff.
- i (2:28) Azotus and Ashkelon: Philistine cities on the coast; Azotus is Ashdod, and Jamnia is Jabneh (Yavneh). Sur and Ocina are not certainly identified.

Chapter 3

1 So they sent envoys to him with offers of peace, who said, 2 "Here we are, servants of the great king Nebuchadnezzar, bowing low in your presence. Deal with us however you see fit. 3 Our farmsteads, all our lands, every wheat field, our flocks and herds, and all the sheepfolds of our encampments lie before you; do with them as you please. 4 Our towns too, with their inhabitants, are your slaves. Come and treat them in whatever way seems good to you." 5 The men came to Holofernes and reported to him in these words.

6 Then he and his army went down to the coast. He stationed garrisons
in the hilltop towns and took picked men from them as auxiliaries.
7 These people and all the surrounding countryside welcomed him
with garlands, dancing and tambourines. 8 Yet he demolished all
their shrines[a] and hacked down their sacred groves; for he had been
commissioned to wipe out every god of the earth, so that every nation
would worship Nebuchadnezzar alone, and people of every tongue
and tribe would call upon him as god.
9 Then he came toward Esdraelon, near Dothan,[b] which faces the
great ridge[c] of Judea. 10 His troops made camp between Geba and
Scythopolis,[d] and he stayed there for a whole month in order to gather
all the supplies for his army.

Notes

- a (3:8) Shrines: so a probable reading; the Greek manuscripts read "borders" (horia), perhaps a confusion with "holy places" (hiera). Scholarly review recommended.
- b (3:9) Dothan: Greek Dōtaia, the Dothan of Genesis 37:17, north of Samaria.
- c (3:9) Ridge: Greek "saw," evidently the jagged mountain ridge running north–south through the hill country (perhaps the Carmel range).
- d (3:10) Scythopolis: the Greek name of Beth-shan, at the eastern end of the Jezreel valley. Geba here is perhaps Jaba, south of Dothan.

Chapter 4

1 The Israelites living in Judea heard of everything that Holofernes,
commander-in-chief of Nebuchadnezzar king of the Assyrians, had
done to the nations, and how he had stripped all their temples and
given them over to destruction. 2 They were utterly terrified at his
approach and were deeply alarmed for Jerusalem and for the Temple
of the Lord their God.[a] 3 For they had only lately come up from captiv-
ity; the people of Judea had only recently been gathered together, and
the vessels, the altar and the house had just been consecrated anew
after their profanation.[b] 4 They dispatched messengers throughout the
territory of Samaria, to Kona and Beth-horon, Belmain and Jericho,
Choba and Aesora, and the Salem valley.[c] 5 They occupied all the
summits of the high mountains, fortified the villages on them, and
laid in provisions in readiness for war, since their fields had just been
harvested.

6 Joakim, high priest[d] in Jerusalem in those days, sent a letter to the
inhabitants of Bethulia[e] and Betomesthaim,[f] which faces Esdraelon
across the plain near Dothan, 7 ordering them to hold the mountain
passes, since through them lay the way into Judea. It would be easy
to stop the enemy as they came up, for the approach was so narrow
that only two men at a time could pass. 8 The Israelites did as Joakim
the high priest and the council of elders of all the people of Israel,
sitting in Jerusalem, had commanded them.
9 All the men of Israel called upon God most earnestly and abased
themselves most earnestly, 10 they, their wives, their little children and
their cattle; every resident alien, hired laborer and purchased slave
among them wrapped sackcloth around their waists. 11 All the men,
women and children of Israel who lived in Jerusalem lay prostrate
before the Temple, strewed ashes on their heads, and spread out their
sackcloth before the Lord. 12 They even draped the altar in sackcloth,
and with one accord they called out earnestly to the God of Israel
not to let their infants be carried off as plunder, their wives taken
as spoil, the towns of their inheritance destroyed, and the sanctuary
profaned and mocked, to the gloating of the nations. 13 The Lord heard
their voice and looked upon their distress. Throughout Judea and in
Jerusalem the people fasted for many days before the sanctuary of
the Lord Almighty.[g] 14 Joakim the high priest, and all the priests who
stood in the Lord's presence and served him, wrapped their loins in
sackcloth as they presented the daily burnt offering, the vow offer-
ings, and the people's voluntary gifts. 15 There were ashes on their
turbans, and with all their might they cried out to the Lord to look
with favor on the whole house of Israel.

Notes

- a (4:2) The Lord their God: in Judith, as elsewhere in the Greek scriptures, Greek kyrios ("Lord") normally stands for the divine name YHWH of the Hebrew Bible, which this translation renders "Yahweh" in books translated from Hebrew. Because Judith survives only in Greek, kyrios is rendered "Lord" throughout. Scholarly review recommended.
- b (4:3) After their profanation: the setting presupposes the return from the Babylonian exile (after 538 BC) and the rebuilding of the Temple, although the king is

called Nebuchadnezzar. Some see an echo of the rededication of the Temple under Judas Maccabeus in 164 BC (1 Maccabees 4:36–59).

- c (4:4) Valley of Salem: most of these places are not certainly identified. Beth-horon lies northwest of Jerusalem; Kona, Belmain, Choba and Aesora are unknown, and Salem may be Salim near the Jordan (compare John 3:23).
- d (4:6) Joakim the high priest: a high priest named Joiakim served after the return from exile (Nehemiah 12:10, 26), but the Joakim of Judith cannot be fixed historically.
- e (4:6) Bethulia: the town where most of the story takes place, otherwise unknown. Its name may be symbolic, suggesting Hebrew betulah, "virgin," or bet-eloah, "house of God." Its setting here, guarding the passes near Dothan, would place it in the hill country north of Samaria; sites such as Mithiliya and Sanur have been proposed (reported).
- f (4:6) Betomesthaim: unidentified.
- g (4:13) The Lord Almighty: Greek kyrios pantokratōr, "Lord, ruler of all," the usual Greek rendering of "Yahweh of hosts."

Chapter 5

1 Word reached Holofernes, commander-in-chief of the Assyrian army, that the Israelites had made ready for war: they had shut off the passes through the hill country, walled in every summit of the high mountains, and laid obstacles across the plains. 2 He was seized with violent anger, and he called together all the rulers of Moab, the generals of Ammon, and all the governors of the coast, 3 and said to them, "Now tell me, you Canaanites, who are these people that inhabit the hill country? What towns do they live in? How large is their army, and where does their power and strength lie? Who has set himself up as their king, to lead their forces? 4 And why, alone among all the peoples of the west, have they turned their backs and refused to come out and meet me?"

5 Then Achior,[a] chief of all the sons of Ammon, replied, "May my lord be pleased to hear a word spoken by your servant. I will give you a true account of this nation dwelling in the highlands close to your camp, and nothing false shall come from your servant's mouth. 6 These people are descended from the Chaldeans.[b] 7 At one time they lived as aliens in Mesopotamia, because they would not follow the gods of their forebears in the land of the Chaldeans. 8 They abandoned their ancestors' customs and began worshiping the God of heaven,

whom they had come to know. Their relatives expelled them from the
presence of their gods, and they escaped to Mesopotamia and lived
there as foreigners for many years. 9 Then their God told them to leave
the place where they were staying and go to the land of Canaan. They
settled there and grew rich in gold and silver and in great herds of
livestock. 10 But hunger overspread the face of Canaan, so they went
down into Egypt and sojourned there while their food held out; and
in that land they grew into a vast throng, a race too many to count.
11 But the king of Egypt rose up against them and dealt craftily with
them, forcing them to toil at brickmaking; they humiliated them and
made them slaves. 12 They raised a cry to their God, who smote all
Egypt with incurable plagues; and so the Egyptians expelled them
from their presence. 13 Then God dried up the Red Sea before them, 14
and led them by the road to Sinai and Kadesh-barnea. They expelled
all who lived in the wilderness, 15 and took up residence in the land
of the Amorites. In their strength they wiped out all the people of
Heshbon, and crossing the Jordan they took possession of the whole
hill country. 16 They dispossessed the Canaanite, the Perizzite, the
Jebusite, the people of Shechem, and every Girgashite, and dwelt in
that land for many days. 17 As long as they did not sin before their
God, prosperity was theirs, for the God who is with them hates
wrongdoing. 18 But when they strayed from the path he had set for
them, they were wiped out in many wars and deported to a foreign
land. Their God's temple was leveled, and their enemies captured
their towns. 19 But now they have come back to their God and returned
from the places where they had been dispersed. They have reoccupied
Jerusalem, the site of their sanctuary, and resettled the hill country,
which had lain deserted.[c] 20 So now, my master and lord, if there is any
error in this people, if they are sinning against their God, and if we
find out that they have this offense among them, then we will go up
and defeat them. 21 But should their people be free of lawlessness, my
lord had best leave them alone, lest their Lord and God shield them
and we become a byword of disgrace in all the earth."
22 When Achior stopped speaking, all the people standing around the
tent began to grumble, and Holofernes' officers and all those from the

coast and from Moab said he ought to be cut to pieces. [23] "We will not be afraid of the Israelites," they said. "They are a people with neither the power nor the might to make a strong stand in battle. [24] So let us go up, Lord Holofernes, and they will be swallowed up by your whole army."

Notes

- a (5:5) Achior: a Hebrew-sounding name, perhaps "brother of light." His later conversion (14:10) makes this Ammonite a notable figure, since Deuteronomy 23:3 excluded Ammonites from the assembly of Israel.
- b (5:6) Chaldeans: that is, from Ur of the Chaldeans (Genesis 11:31). Achior's summary of Israel's history follows Genesis through Kings.
- c (5:19) Left desolate: this presupposes the return from exile (after 538 BC), centuries after the historical Nebuchadnezzar of Assyria in the story. See the note at 1:1.

Chapter 6

[1] When the uproar among the men around the council had subsided, Holofernes, commander-in-chief of the Assyrian army, spoke to Achior in front of the whole crowd of foreigners and of all the Moabites: [2] "And who are you, Achior, you and these hirelings of Ephraim,[a] to play the prophet among us as you have done today, telling us not to make war on the race of Israel because their God will protect them? Who is god but Nebuchadnezzar? His power he will dispatch to wipe them from the earth's face, and their God will not rescue them. [3] We his servants will strike them down as if they were one man. They will not withstand the might of our cavalry. [4] We will burn them up with it;[b] the blood of these people will make their hills drunk, and their corpses will fill their lowlands. Not even the print of their feet will stand against us; they will perish utterly. This is the word of King Nebuchadnezzar, master of all the earth; and when he speaks, not one thing he says will prove empty. [5] As for you, Achior, you Ammonite hireling, who have uttered these words in your hour of wickedness, from this day you will not see my face again until I take vengeance on this race that came out of Egypt. [6] Then the iron of my army and the spear[c] of my servants will run through your ribs, and you will drop down among their slain at my return. [7] My slaves

will now take you back into the hill country and leave you in one of the towns beside the passes. [8] You will not die until you are destroyed along with them. [9] And if in your heart you are so confident they will not be taken, why let your face fall? I have said it; no word of mine will come to nothing."
[10] Then Holofernes commanded the slaves who attended him in his tent to arrest Achior, conduct him back to Bethulia, and deliver him into Israelite hands. [11] His slaves therefore seized him, marched him outside the camp onto the plain, and from the middle of the plain headed up into the highlands until they reached the springs beneath Bethulia. [12] When the men of the hilltop town saw them, they grabbed their weapons and went out to the crest of the hill, and all the slingers prevented them from climbing by showering them with stones. [13] So they slipped down under cover of the hill, bound Achior, left him lying at the foot of the hill, and went back to their lord. [14] Coming down out of their town, the Israelites went over to him, loosed his bonds, brought him into Bethulia, and stood him before the magistrates of their town, [15] who in those days were these: Uzziah[d] the son of Micah, a Simeonite; Chabris the son of Gothoniel; and Charmis the son of Melchiel. [16] These summoned every elder of the town; all the youths and the women came running to the gathering; and Achior was made to stand in the midst of the whole populace while Uzziah asked him what had occurred. [17] He answered by relating what had been said at Holofernes' council, everything he himself had said before the Assyrian officers, and all of Holofernes' bragging against Israel's house. [18] Then the people bowed down in worship before God and called aloud, [19] "Lord God of heaven, look on their arrogance, and pity the humiliation of our race. Look with favor today on the faces of those who are consecrated to you." [20] Then they reassured Achior and praised him highly. [21] Uzziah brought him from the gathering to his house and held a drinking feast for the elders, and through the whole of that night they called upon Israel's God to help them.

Notes

- a (6:2) Hirelings of Ephraim: a taunt, suggesting that Achior has been bought by the Israelites; Ephraim stands for Israel. Some manuscripts read "hireling of Ammon," as in verse 5.
- b (6:4) With it: perhaps "with them," that is, with our cavalry, or "in their own land." The Greek is obscure.
- c (6:6) Spear: literally "people," perhaps by confusion with a similar word; the parallel with "sword" suggests a weapon. Scholarly review recommended.
- d (6:15) Uzziah: "Yahweh is my strength."

Chapter 7

1 On the following day Holofernes gave orders to his whole army,
and to all the peoples who had joined him as allies, to break camp
and march against Bethulia, to seize beforehand the ascents into the
hill country, and to open war on the Israelites. 2 That day every
fighting man among them set out. Their force of warriors numbered
one hundred seventy thousand foot soldiers and twelve thousand
horsemen,[a] not counting the baggage train and the men on foot who
went with it, a vast host indeed. 3 They pitched camp in the valley
close to Bethulia, beside the spring. Their camp stretched in breadth
toward Dothan as far as Belbaim, and in length from Bethulia to
Cyamon,[b] which looks out over Esdraelon.

4 When the Israelites caught sight of that multitude they were badly
shaken, and each one said to his neighbor, "These men will now lick
clean the whole face of the earth. Neither the high mountains nor the
ravines nor the hills will bear their weight." 5 Each man took up his
weapons of war, and after kindling beacon fires on their towers they
stood guard all that night.

6 On the second day Holofernes paraded all his cavalry within sight
of the Israelites in Bethulia. 7 He inspected the approaches to their
town and searched out its springs of water. These he took over,
posting detachments of soldiers at them, and then went back to his
own troops.

8 Then all the chiefs of the descendants of Esau, all the leaders of the
Moabite people, and the commanders of the coastland came to him
and said, 9 "Will our master please listen to a word, so that no disaster
strikes your army? 10 This people, the Israelites, put no trust in their

spears; they rely on the heights of the mountains where they make
their homes, for the summits of their mountains are hard to reach. 11
So, master, do not fight them in regular battle formation, and not a
single man of your troops will fall. 12 Remain in your camp and keep
every soldier of your army safe. Let your servants instead get control
of the spring that flows from the foot of the mountain, 13 since that
is where all the inhabitants of Bethulia draw their water. Thirst will
destroy them and they will hand over their town. Meanwhile we and
our people will climb the nearby mountain peaks and camp on them
as an outpost, so that not one man gets out of the town. 14 They, their
wives and their children will waste away from hunger, and before the
sword ever reaches them they will lie strewn in the streets where they
live. 15 In this way you will pay them back with an evil reward, because
they rebelled and would not come out peaceably to meet you."
16 Holofernes and all his attendants were pleased with this advice, and
he ordered it carried out as proposed. 17 Accordingly the Ammonite
force broke camp, and five thousand Assyrian troops with them;
pitching their tents along the valley, they took control of the
Israelites' waters and the fountains that fed them. 18 Edom's sons
and Ammon's sons, for their part, climbed up and made camp in the
highlands facing Dothan, and detached some of their number to the
south and east, toward Egrebel near Chus, on the Mochmur ravine.[c]
The remainder of the Assyrian host took up position on the plain
and blanketed the whole countryside; their tents and baggage were
pitched in one enormous crowd, a host beyond measure.
19 Then Israel's people raised a cry to the Lord their God, since their
courage had sunk; every foe of theirs ringed them about, and there
was no slipping out from the midst of them. 20 The whole Assyrian
force, infantry, chariots and cavalry, kept them surrounded for thirty-
four days, until every water jar belonging to the people of Bethulia
was empty. 21 Their cisterns were running dry, and there was not a
single day on which they had water enough to drink, for it was doled
out to them by measure. 22 Their children lost courage, while the
women and youths collapsed from thirst in the town squares and the
gateways; they had no strength left.

23 Then the whole people, young men, women and children, thronged
around Uzziah and the rulers of the town, and with loud cries they
said before all the elders, 24 "God be judge between you and us! You
have done us a grave wrong by not making terms of peace with the
Assyrians. 25 Now no one can help us. God has handed us over to
them, to be crushed in front of them by thirst and total destruction.
26 Summon them now and surrender the whole town to be plundered
by the troops of Holofernes and all his army. 27 It is better for us to
become their prey; we will be slaves, but we will stay alive, and we
will not have to watch our infants die before our eyes, or our wives
and children breathing their last. 28 Heaven and earth we summon
as witnesses against you, and our God, Lord of our fathers, who is
punishing us as our own sins and our fathers' sins deserve: may he
not act today according to these words!" 29 Then the entire assembly
broke into loud weeping with one voice, and they cried out to the
Lord God at the top of their voices. 30 Uzziah said to them, "Courage,
my brothers! Let us hold out five days more. In that time the Lord our
God will turn his mercy toward us again, for he will not forsake us
utterly. 31 But if these days pass with no help reaching us, I will do as
you say." 32 Then he sent the people away, each to his own post. The
men went off to the walls and towers of their town, and they sent the
women and children home. And there was deep dejection throughout
the town.

Notes

- a (7:2) Twelve thousand horsemen: compare 2:15, where the force numbers 120,000 infantry and 12,000 mounted archers. The figures are those of the story, not of history.
- b (7:3) Cyamon: Belbaim (perhaps the Belmain of 4:4) and Cyamon are not certainly identified; Cyamon may be Tell Qaimun (Jokneam), at the western edge of the Jezreel valley (reported).
- c (7:18) Wadi Mochmur: Egrebel may be Akrabbeh, southeast of Shechem; Chus and the Wadi Mochmur are unidentified (reported).

Chapter 8

1 In those days word of all this reached Judith.[a] She was the daughter
of Merari, and her ancestry went back through Ox, Joseph, Oziel,

Elkiah, Ananias, Gideon and Raphain, Ahitub, Elijah, Hilkiah, Eliab, Nathanael, Salamiel, and Sarasadai, up to Israel himself.[b] 2 Her husband Manasseh, from her own tribe and clan, had died during the barley harvest (April–May).[c] 3 While he stood over the men binding sheaves in the field, the burning heat struck his head; he took to his bed and died in Bethulia, his own town, and was laid to rest beside his fathers in the countryside lying between Dothan and Balamon. 4 For three years and four months now Judith had been living as a widow at home. 5 On the roof of her house she had put up a tent for herself. She wore sackcloth around her waist and dressed in the garments of her widowhood. 6 All the days of her widowhood she kept a fast, apart from sabbath eves and sabbaths, new-moon eves and new moons, and the feasts and joyful occasions of Israel's house.[d] 7 She was lovely in form and very beautiful to look upon. Her husband Manasseh had left her gold and silver, male and female servants, livestock and fields, and she remained on her estate. 8 No one spoke a word of ill against her, for she feared God greatly.

9 When Judith learned of the bitter words the people had spoken against their ruler, disheartened as they were by the lack of water, and learned too of all that Uzziah had said to them, how he had sworn to hand the town over to the Assyrians after five days, 10 she sent her maid,[e] who managed all her property, to summon Chabris and Charmis, the elders of her town. 11 When they arrived she said to them, "Hear me, you who govern Bethulia's inhabitants! The word you spoke before the people today was not right. You have sworn this oath, pronounced between God and yourselves, pledging to give up the city to our foes if within those days the Lord does not turn to bring you aid. 12 Who are you, then, to make trial of God this very day and to stand in God's stead in the midst of mortals? 13 Now you are probing the Lord Almighty, yet you will never understand anything! 14 You cannot fathom the depths of the human heart or grasp what a person is thinking. How then can you search out God, who made all these things, or read his mind, or comprehend his reasoning? No, my brothers, do not provoke the Lord our God to anger. 15 For if he does not choose to help us within five days, he still has power to protect

us on any day he wishes, or else to destroy us before our enemies. [16] Do not try to bind the Lord our God by pledges as to his plans. God is no man, that threats should move him, nor a son of man, to be brought to terms.[f] [17] So while we wait for the deliverance that comes from him, let us call on him to help us, and he will hear our voice if it pleases him.

[18] "For in our generations there has never arisen, nor is there now, any tribe or clan or district or town of ours that bows down to gods made by hands, as happened in former times. [19] It was for this that our fathers were given up to the sword and to pillage and fell with a great fall in the sight of our foes. [20] We, however, know no god other than him; and so we hope he will not look past us or past any of our race. [21] For if we are taken, all Judea will be taken likewise, and our holy places will be plundered; and God will require of us, at the cost of our blood, their profanation. [22] The killing of our kin, the land's captivity, the laying waste of our inheritance, all this he will turn back upon our heads among whatever nations we come to serve; and we will become a thing to stumble over and to scorn in our owners' sight. [23] Our servitude will not end in goodwill; rather the Lord our God will make it a disgrace.

[24] "Therefore, brothers, let us show our kin what we are made of, since their very lives hang upon us, and on us rest the holy things, the house and the altar. [25] Whatever happens, let us thank the Lord our God, who is putting us through a trial just as he did our ancestors. [26] Call to mind his dealings with Abraham, his testing of Isaac, and what befell Jacob in Mesopotamia of Syria as he shepherded the flocks of Laban, his mother's brother. [27] He has not put us through the fire as he did them, to search out their hearts, nor has he exacted punishment from us; it is for warning that the Lord lashes those who come near him."

[28] Uzziah answered her, "All that you have said, you have spoken with a good heart, and there is no one who can stand against your words. [29] This is not the first day your wisdom has come to light. Since your earliest days the whole people has known how discerning you are, because what your heart shapes is good. [30] But the people were

terribly thirsty, and they compelled us to act as we promised them and to bind ourselves by an oath that we cannot break. 31 So now pray for us, for you are a devout woman, and the Lord will send rain to fill our cisterns, and we will no longer faint."
32 Judith said to them, "Listen to me. I am going to do a deed that will be told to the children of our race from generation to generation. 33 Station yourselves at the town gate tonight, and I will go out with my maid. Before the day you set for handing the town over to our enemies, the Lord will rescue Israel through me. 34 But you are not to inquire into my doing. I will tell you nothing until the thing I am to do has been accomplished." 35 Uzziah and the magistrates replied, "Depart in peace. The Lord God be ahead of you, to repay our enemies!" 36 Then they turned away from the tent and went back to their stations.

Notes

- a (8:1) Judith: Hebrew Yehudit, "Jewess" or "Judean woman," the feminine of Judah. The name presents her as an embodiment of her people, much as her town Bethulia and her husband Manasseh may carry symbolic weight. Her long genealogy, the longest given for any woman in the Greek Bible, underlines her standing.
- b (8:1) Son of Israel: that is, son of Jacob. Several names in the list (Merari, Ox, Sarasadai) are uncertain, and the manuscripts differ; Latin and some Greek witnesses connect her with the tribe of Simeon (compare 9:2). Scholarly review recommended.
- c (8:2) Barley harvest: in Palestine the barley harvest fell in the spring, in the months of Nisan and Iyyar.
- d (8:6) Of the house of Israel: Judith exempts the days on which Jewish practice forbade fasting. The rules about the eves of sabbaths and new moons reflect later Jewish custom (compare Mishnah, Taanit).
- e (8:10) Her maid: Greek habra, a favorite or personal maid, one who has charge of a household.
- f (8:16) Won over by bargaining: or "to be brought to terms"; the Greek speaks of submitting a case to arbitration.

Chapter 9

1 Then Judith threw herself face down, sprinkled ash over her head, and laid bare the sackcloth she had on beneath. At that very hour in Jerusalem the evening incense[a] was being offered in God's house, and Judith called aloud to the Lord, saying: 2 "Lord, God of Simeon my forefather, into whose hand you put a sword to take revenge

on the foreigners who had loosened a virgin's girdle to defile her, stripped her thigh to shame her, and polluted her womb to disgrace her[b]—for you had said, 'This shall not be done,' yet they did it— 3 for that deed you gave up their rulers to slaughter, and their bed, which blushed at their deceit, you made a bed deceived and bloodied.[c] You struck down slaves together with princes, and princes upon their thrones. 4 Their wives you gave up as plunder and their daughters as captives, with all their loot divided among the sons you loved, who were fired with zeal for you, who abhorred the defilement of their blood and appealed to you for help. God, my God, listen to me too, a widow. 5 For it is you who brought about those events and what went before them and what came after. The present and the things yet to come you have planned, and what you had in mind has come to pass. 6 What you intended stood by your side and answered, 'Look, we are present!' Every road of yours lies ready, and you judge with knowledge beforehand.

7 "See, the Assyrians are swollen with their might. They exult in horse and rider; they glory in the strength of their infantry; their trust is in buckler and javelin, bow and sling, and they fail to recognize you as the Lord who crushes wars. 8 Lord is your name.[d] Break their strength by your power; bring down their might in your anger. For they have resolved to defile your holy places, to pollute the tabernacle where your glorious name rests, and to hew down the horn of your altar with iron. 9 Look upon their pride; send your fury on their heads. Give into my hand, a widow's hand, strength for what I have planned. 10 By the guile of my lips strike down slave together with master, and master together with servant. Shatter their arrogance by the hand of a woman.

11 "For your strength does not lie in numbers, nor your sovereignty in the mighty. God of the humble you are, aid of the little ones, upholder of the feeble, shelter for the despairing, rescuer of the hopeless. 12 Yes, O yes, my father's God, God of Israel's inheritance, master of the heavens and the earth, maker of the seas, sovereign over everything you have made: listen to my plea! 13 Make my words and my deceit a wound and a bruise to those who have plotted cruel things against

your covenant, against your consecrated house, against the summit of Zion, and against the house your children possess. 14 Let all your people and every tribe come to acknowledge and perceive that you are God, God of every power and strength, and that there is no other who shields the race of Israel but you alone!"

Notes

- a (9:1) The evening incense: incense was burned in the Temple every evening and morning (Exodus 30:7–8), and the evening offering became a customary hour of prayer (compare Psalm 141:2; Daniel 9:21).
- b (9:2) To disgrace her: the rape of Dinah, avenged by her brothers Simeon and Levi (Genesis 34). Judith's prayer approves the vengeance that Genesis 49:5–7 condemns.
- c (9:3) Deceived and bloodied: the Greek is compressed; the sense seems to be that the bed on which the Shechemites had acted deceitfully became the place where they were deceived and killed.
- d (9:8) Lord is your name: compare Exodus 15:3, "Yahweh is his name." Here the Greek kyrios plainly stands for the divine name. See the note at 4:2.

Chapter 10

1 When she had ceased crying out to the God of Israel and had brought all these words to a close, 2 she rose from where she lay prostrate, called her maid, and went down into the house where she used to spend her sabbaths and her feast days. 3 She took off the sackcloth that clothed her and put aside her widow's garments. She bathed her body in water and anointed herself with rich ointment, combed out the hair of her head and set a headband on it, and put on the festive clothes she used to wear while her husband Manasseh was alive. 4 Sandals she bound on her feet, and she put on her ankle chains, bangles, finger rings, earrings and all her finery. Thus she adorned herself lavishly, so as to beguile the eyes of any men who might see her. 5 She gave her maid a wineskin and a flask of oil, packed a bag with parched grain, fig cakes, and loaves of ritually clean bread,[a] tied up all her supplies, and handed them to the maid to carry.

6 Then they went out to the gate of the town of Bethulia and found Uzziah standing there with the town elders, Chabris and Charmis. 7 When these men saw her, her face transformed and her clothing changed, they were struck with exceeding wonder at her beauty and

said to her, [8] "May the God of our fathers grant you favor and bring your undertakings to fulfillment, to the glory of Israel's people and the exaltation of Jerusalem." [9] She bowed to worship God and told them, "Order the town gate opened for me, and I will go out to carry through the plan you and I discussed." So they told the young men to open it for her, as she had asked. [10] This they did. Judith went out, she and her servant girl with her, and the men of the town kept her in sight until she had gone down the mountain and crossed the valley; after that they could see her no longer.

[11] The two of them were walking straight ahead along the ravine when an Assyrian patrol met her. [12] Taking her into custody, they questioned her: "Whose are you? Where do you come from, and where are you going?" She answered, "I am a daughter of the Hebrews,[b] and I am running away from them, since they are about to be given over to you to be devoured. [13] I am on my way to Holofernes, the commander of your army, to give him a truthful report. I will show him a road he can take to make himself master of the whole hill country without losing one of his men, body or breath." [14] As the men listened to her words and studied her face, she seemed to them marvelously beautiful, and they said to her, [15] "You have saved your life by hurrying down to our lord's presence. Go now to his tent; some of us will escort you until they put you into his hands. [16] And when you stand before him, have no fear in your heart. Report to him as you have spoken, and he will deal kindly with you." [17] They chose a hundred of their men to accompany her and her maid, and these brought them to the tent of Holofernes.

[18] People came running from all over the camp, for the news of her arrival spread from tent to tent. They gathered in a ring about her where she stood in front of Holofernes' tent until they had told him about her. [19] They marveled at her beauty, and judged the Israelites by her. "Who could despise these people," they said to one another, "when they have women like this among them? It would be a mistake to leave even one of their men alive, for if they were let go they would be able to outwit the whole world!"

20 Then out came those who slept near Holofernes,[c] together with
every servant of his, and they led her inside. 21 Holofernes was resting
on his bed under the canopy,[d] which was woven of purple and gold,
with emeralds and other precious stones. 22 When they told him about
her, he came out into the front part of the tent, with silver lamps
carried before him. 23 As Judith came before him and his attendants,
they all marveled at the beauty of her face. She fell on her face and
did obeisance to him, and his slaves raised her up.

Notes

- a (10:5) Ritually pure bread: literally "pure loaves," food prepared in keeping with the Jewish dietary laws, so that she would not have to eat the food of the Gentiles (compare 12:1–4). The Greek words for her containers do not imply fixed measures.
- b (10:12) Daughter of the Hebrews: that is, a Hebrew woman. "Hebrew" is the name Israelites typically used of themselves when speaking to foreigners.
- c (10:20) Those who slept near Holofernes: his personal attendants or bodyguards.
- d (10:21) Canopy: Greek kōnōpion, a net or curtain hung around a bed to keep off gnats and mosquitoes; the source of English "canopy." It reappears at 13:9 and 16:19.

Chapter 11

1 Holofernes spoke to her: "Be brave, lady; do not be afraid at heart.
Never yet have I done hurt to any man who elected to be a servant of
Nebuchadnezzar, sovereign of the whole earth. 2 As for your nation
up in the highlands, if they had not treated me with contempt I
should not have raised a spear against them. It is their own doing. 3
But tell me now, why did you run away from them and come over
to us? You have come to safety. Courage! You will live through this
night and through all the nights to follow. 4 No one is going to wrong
you; rather, you will be treated well, as the servants of my lord King
Nebuchadnezzar are."
5 Judith said in reply, "Receive what your bondwoman has to say, and
allow your handmaid to address you face to face; not one lie will I
speak to my lord[a] tonight. 6 If you follow the advice of your servant
girl, God will bring the matter to a full conclusion through you, and
my lord will not fail in his designs. 7 As surely as Nebuchadnezzar
lives, king of all the earth, and as his power lives, who sent you
to set every living being in order, not only do human beings serve

him because of you, but through your strength the wild animals, the cattle and the birds of the sky will live for Nebuchadnezzar and all his house.[b] 8 We have heard of your wisdom and your clever designs. It is reported throughout the world that you alone are excellent in all the kingdom, mighty in knowledge, and wonderful in military strategy.
9 "Now as for the speech Achior made at your council, we have heard what he said, for the men of Bethulia spared him, and he told them all that he had declared before you. 10 Therefore, my master and lord, do not brush aside what he said, but remember it, because it is true. Our people cannot be punished, and the sword cannot overcome them, unless they sin against their God. 11 "But now, so that my lord may not be thwarted and his purpose fail, death is about to fall upon them. A sin has taken hold of them by which they will anger their God whenever they commit this outrage. 12 Since their food is giving out and their water is almost gone, they have decided to lay hands on their livestock, and they have resolved to consume everything that God by his laws forbade them to eat. 13 The firstlings of the grain, too, and the tenths of wine and oil, which they had hallowed and kept back for the priests who stand before our God's face in Jerusalem, they now mean to devour entirely, holy things that none of the common people is permitted even to handle.[c] 14 They have sent men to Jerusalem to bring back permission from the council of elders, because even the people living there have done this. 15 Once word reaches them and they carry it out, that same day they will be surrendered to you to be wiped out.
16 "Because of this, once your bondwoman knew all these things, I made my escape from them; and God has dispatched me to do deeds together with you that will leave the world astonished, everyone who comes to hear them. 17 For your slave is a God-fearing woman who worships the God of heaven night and day. Now, my lord, I will remain with you, but every night your slave will go out into the ravine and pray to God, and he will tell me when they have committed their sins. 18 Then I will return and let you know, and you will sally forth at the head of all your forces, and none of them will be able to withstand you. 19 I will lead you through the middle of Judea until

you come to Jerusalem, and I will set your seat[d] in its midst. You will drive them like sheep without a shepherd, and not even a dog will so much as growl at you.[e] These things were told me through my foreknowledge; they were revealed to me, and I have been sent to announce them to you."
20 Holofernes and his whole retinue were delighted with what she said; her wisdom amazed them, and they exclaimed, 21 "From one end of the earth to the other there is no woman like her for beauty of face and wisdom of speech!" 22 Holofernes told her, "God did well in sending you on before your people, so that strength might come into our hands, and ruin upon those who have slighted my lord. 23 Charming you are to look upon, and fine in what you say. Should you carry out what you have promised, your God will be my God,[f] and in King Nebuchadnezzar's house you will have a place, and your name will be famous across the earth."

Notes

- a (11:5) My lord: Judith's speech is full of double meanings. "My lord" (Greek kyrios) can refer to Holofernes or to God, and much of what she says (verses 6, 16, 19) is true in a sense Holofernes does not perceive.
- b (11:7) All his house: the language echoes Jeremiah 27:6, where God gives even the wild animals to serve Nebuchadnezzar.
- c (11:13) With his hands: first fruits and tithes belonged to the priests (Numbers 18:12–13, 21–32; Deuteronomy 18:4). Eating them was a grave offense for anyone else.
- d (11:19) Seat: Greek diphros, a seat or chair, here the chair of state or chariot seat of a conqueror.
- e (11:19) Growl at you: compare Exodus 11:7. "Like sheep without a shepherd" echoes 1 Kings 22:17.
- f (11:23) Your God shall be my God: an ironic echo of Ruth 1:16.

Chapter 12

1 Then he ordered her to be brought into the place where his silver dinnerware was kept, and gave instructions that a table be laid for her with some of his own delicacies and that she be served his own wine to drink. 2 But Judith said, "I will not eat any of it, lest it become a cause of offense.[a] I will be supplied from the things I have brought with me." 3 Holofernes said to her, "But if what you have with you

runs out, where can we get you more of the same? None of your race is here with us." [4] Judith replied, "By your life, my lord, before your bondwoman has used up the supplies I carry, the Lord will have accomplished through my hand the thing he has resolved."
[5] Then Holofernes' attendants brought her into the tent, and she slept on into the middle of the night. Toward the morning watch[b] she got up [6] and sent a message to Holofernes: "My lord, kindly command that your bondwoman be let out for prayer." [7] Holofernes ordered his guards not to stop her. She stayed in the camp for three days, and each night went out to the Bethulia ravine and washed at the spring in the camp.[c] [8] After coming up from it, she would plead with the Lord, the God of Israel, to guide her path for the rescue of her people.
[9] Then she would return purified and remain in the tent until she ate her food toward evening.
[10] When the fourth day came, Holofernes gave a drinking party for his personal servants alone and summoned none of those on duty. [11] To Bagoas,[d] the eunuch who had charge of everything that was his, he said, "Go now and coax this Hebrew woman staying with you to come and share our food and drink. [12] It would be a disgrace to us if we let such a woman go without enjoying her company. If we do not win her over, she will laugh at us."
[13] So Bagoas left Holofernes' presence and went to her. "Let not this fair girl be reluctant," he said, "to come before my lord, to be honored in his sight, to join us in drinking wine for gladness, and this day to become like one of the daughters of Assyria who wait upon Nebuchadnezzar in his palace." [14] Judith answered, "And who am I to say no to my lord? Anything that seems good in his eyes I will hurry to do, and it will be my delight till the day I die."[e] [15] So she arose and arrayed herself in her clothing and all her woman's finery. Her maid went ahead and spread on the ground for her, opposite Holofernes, the fleeces she had received from Bagoas for her daily use, so that she might recline on them to eat.
[16] Judith came in and lay down. At the sight of her Holofernes was beside himself; he was shaken to the soul and gripped by a fierce longing to have her, for ever since the day he first set eyes on her

he had been watching for a chance to beguile her. [17] "Come, drink!" Holofernes urged her. "Share our merriment!" [18] Judith answered, "Indeed I will drink, my lord, for today my life means more to me than in all the days since I was born." [19] Then she took the food her maid had prepared and ate and drank in front of him. [20] Holofernes took such pleasure in her that he poured down wine in vast amounts, more than he had ever drunk in a single day in all his life.

Notes

- a (12:2) Offense: Greek skandalon, a stumbling block; that is, a violation of the Jewish dietary laws (compare Daniel 1:8; Tobit 1:10–11).
- b (12:5) The morning watch: the last watch of the night, before dawn.
- c (12:7) At the spring in the camp: she bathes for ritual purity before prayer. Some manuscripts omit "in the camp."
- d (12:11) Bagoas: a Persian name, borne by the powerful eunuch who served Artaxerxes III in the fourth century BC (Diodorus 16.47; reported). Its use here is another of the book's Persian-period touches.
- e (12:14) The day of my death: like 11:5, an answer that Holofernes hears as submission, but which the reader hears as loyalty to the Lord.

Chapter 13

[1] As evening came on, his slaves made haste to withdraw. Bagoas shut the tent from outside, closing off the attendants from his master's presence, and they went off to their beds; all of them were worn out, because the drinking had gone on so long. [2] Judith was left by herself in the tent, with Holofernes sprawled across his bed, for he was sodden with wine. [3] Judith had told her maid to wait outside her bedchamber and watch for her to come out, as on other days, since she said she would be going out to pray; and she had spoken to Bagoas in the same terms. [4] Everyone left his presence, and no one, young or old, remained in the bedroom. Then Judith, standing next to his bed, prayed silently: "Lord, God of all might, look now at what my hands are about to do for the glory of Jerusalem. [5] For now is the moment to come to the aid of your heritage and to carry out my design for the shattering of the enemies who have risen up against us." [6] Stepping to the post of the bed that stood at Holofernes' head, she unhooked his short sword[a] that hung there. [7] Drawing close to the bed, she grasped the hair of his head and said, "Lord God of Israel,

give me strength this day!” 8 Then with all her might she struck at his
neck twice and cut off his head. 9 She rolled his body off the bedding
and pulled the canopy down from the posts. A moment later she went
out and handed Holofernes’ head to her maid, 10 who put it into her
food bag. Then the two of them went out together, as was their habit,
to pray. They passed through the camp, skirted that ravine, climbed
the mountain to Bethulia and came to its gates.
11 From a distance Judith hailed the sentries at the gates: “Open up,
open the gate! God is with us, our God, still working might in Israel
and power over our foes, as he has today!” 12 When the men of her
town heard her voice, they hurried down to the gate of their town
and summoned the elders. 13 Everyone, from the least to the greatest,
came running, for it seemed past belief that she had returned. They
opened the gate and let the women in, then lit a fire to see by and
crowded around them. 14 In a ringing voice she called out to them,
“Give praise to God, give praise! Praise the God who has not taken
away his kindness from Israel’s house, but by my hand has broken
our foes tonight!” 15 Then she pulled the head from the bag, lifted it up,
and told them, “Look, the head of Holofernes, general of the Assyrian
army, and here is the netting under which he lay in his stupor. The
Lord has struck him down by a woman’s hand.[b] 16 As the Lord lives,
who protected me on the way I went, it was my face that seduced
him to his destruction; yet he committed no sin with me to defile and
shame me.”
17 Astonishment seized the whole people; they bent low in worship
of God and said together, “Blessed be you, our God, who today have
made nothing of your people’s enemies!” 18 Uzziah then said to her,
“My daughter, the Most High God has blessed you beyond every
woman upon the earth;[c] and blessed be the Lord God, maker of
heaven and earth, who directed you to wound the head of the chief of
our enemies. 19 Never shall the hope you showed[d] fade from the hearts
of people as they remember God’s might, for all ages. 20 God grant
that this be an everlasting glory to you, and may he visit you with
blessings, since you did not hold back your own life when our people

were humbled, but went out to meet our fall, walking a straight road before our God." And all the people said, "Amen! Amen!"[e]

Notes

- a (13:6) Short sword: Greek akinakēs, the Persian short sword or dagger, another Persian-period detail.
- b (13:15) The hand of a woman: compare Judges 4:9, 21 (Jael and Sisera) and 9:53–54 (Abimelech). The phrase answers Judith's prayer at 9:10.
- c (13:18) Above all the women on earth: compare the blessing on Jael in Judges 5:24, and on Mary in Luke 1:42.
- d (13:19) Your hope: some manuscripts read "your praise."
- e (13:20) Amen! Amen!: Greek genoito, genoito, "so be it, so be it," the usual Greek rendering of Hebrew amen.

Chapter 14

1 Then Judith told them, "Brothers, hear me. Take this head and fasten
it up on the battlements of your wall. 2 When dawn lights the sky and
the sun comes up over the land, each of you is to take his gear of war,
and every strong man is to march out of the town. Put a leader at
their head, as though you meant to go down into the plain upon the
Assyrian outpost; only do not go down. 3 Then they will seize their
arms and hurry to their camp and rouse the officers of the Assyrian
army. These will rush to the tent of Holofernes and will not find him.
Panic will fall on them, and they will flee before you. 4 Then you, and
everyone who dwells anywhere in Israel's territory, must follow on
their heels and strike them down along their roads. 5 But first, before
any of this, call Achior the Ammonite to me, that he may look on and
know the man who held Israel's house in contempt and packed him
off to us as though to die."
6 They therefore sent for Achior from Uzziah's house. When he ar-
rived and beheld Holofernes' head in a man's hand amid the gathered
people, he fell forward on his face and his senses left him. 7 Once
they had lifted him up, he dropped at Judith's feet and bowed down
before her, saying, "May you be blessed in all Judah's dwellings, and
among all nations! Whoever hears your name will tremble. 8 So now,
relate to me everything you have done during these days." Judith
then recounted to him before all the people everything she had done

from the day she left until the hour she spoke with them. 9 When she finished speaking, the people raised a great shout, and their town rang with joyful noise. 10 When Achior saw all that the God of Israel had done, he believed in God firmly. He was circumcised, and was joined to the house of Israel, remaining so to this day.[a]
11 As soon as day broke, they hung the head of Holofernes from the wall. Every man took up his weapons, and they went out by companies to the passes in the mountains. 12 When the Assyrians saw them, they sent a message to their commanders, who went to the generals, the captains over thousands, and every other officer. 13 They came to Holofernes' tent and said to the steward of all his household, "Wake our lord, for the slaves have dared to come down against us to give battle, to their own utter destruction." 14 So Bagoas went in and knocked at the entrance of the tent,[b] for he supposed that Holofernes was sleeping with Judith. 15 When no one answered, he opened it and went into the bedchamber and found him sprawled dead on the platform,[c] with his head cut off and gone. 16 He cried out with a loud voice, weeping and groaning and shouting, and tore his clothes. 17 Then he went into the tent where Judith had been lodging; finding her gone, he leaped out among the troops and cried, 18 "The slaves have broken faith! A single Hebrew woman has put shame on King Nebuchadnezzar's house. See: Holofernes on the ground, and no head on him!" 19 On hearing these words the Assyrian army's chiefs ripped their tunics, their spirits were thrown into turmoil, and a mighty cry and clamor went up in the midst of the camp.

Notes

- a (14:10) To this day: Deuteronomy 23:3 forbade Ammonites to enter the assembly of the LORD. Achior's full acceptance into Israel by circumcision is one of the book's striking features; later rabbinic discussion debated how such a rule applied (reported). Scholarly review recommended.
- b (14:14) The entrance of the tent: literally "the curtain of the tent," perhaps clapping his hands before it, since one could not knock on a curtain.
- c (14:15) Platform: Greek chelōnis, literally "tortoise," apparently the low step or footboard of a couch. The sense is uncertain.

Chapter 15

1 When those still in their tents heard it, they were dumbfounded at
what had happened. 2 Fear and trembling fell upon them; no man
held his place beside his comrade any longer, but streaming out all
together they fled along every track across the plain and through the
hill country. 3 Those who had camped in the hills around Bethulia
were routed as well. Then the Israelites, every fighting man among
them, poured out against them. 4 Uzziah sent messengers to Betomas-
thaim, Bebai, Choba and Kola,[a] and throughout Israel's territory, to
report what had been accomplished and to urge all of them to pour
out upon the enemy and destroy them. 5 On hearing this, the Israelites
with one accord fell upon them and cut them down as far as Choba.
Men came also from Jerusalem and from all the hill country, for word
had reached them of what had befallen the enemy's camp. Those in
Gilead and in Galilee outflanked them and inflicted heavy losses, until
they had passed Damascus and its borders. 6 The remaining people
of Bethulia swept down on the Assyrian camp, plundered it, and
became very rich. 7 The Israelites, returning from the slaughter, took
possession of what was left; and the villages and farmsteads of the
hill country and the plain seized a great deal of booty, for there was
an immense quantity of it.

8 Then the high priest Joakim, together with the council of elders of
Israel resident in Jerusalem, arrived to view the benefits the Lord had
wrought for Israel, to see Judith with their own eyes, and to wish her
peace. 9 When they came to her, they all blessed her with one voice
and said to her, "You are Jerusalem's pride, Israel's great glory, the
great boast of our race! 10 "All this your hand has achieved; you have
wrought blessing for Israel, and God has been pleased with them.
May the Lord Almighty bless you for ever and ever!" And all the
people said, "Amen!"

11 For thirty days the whole people stripped the camp of spoil. To
Judith they presented Holofernes' tent, every piece of his silver plate,
his couches and drinking bowls, and all his gear. She accepted these,
packed her mule, yoked her wagons, and piled everything onto them.
12 Every woman in Israel hurried to see her; they called down blessings

on her, and a band of them formed a dance for her. In her hands she took leafy wands,[b] and passed them to the women about her; [13] and she and her companions wore wreaths of olive leaves. She walked in front of everyone in the dance, leading all the women, while all Israel's men followed, armed and garlanded, singing as they went. [14] Judith began this song of thanksgiving before all Israel, and all the people loudly sang this hymn of praise after her.[c]

Notes

- a (15:4) Kola: Betomasthaim is probably the Betomesthaim of 4:6. Bebai, Choba (compare 4:4) and Kola are unidentified.
- b (15:12) Leafy wands: Greek thyrsoi, the leafy staffs carried in processions in honor of Dionysus. Here they are simply festive emblems (compare 2 Maccabees 10:7).
- c (15:14) After her: this verse is 16:1 in the Latin-based numbering of the KJV Apocrypha, where chapter 15 has 13 verses and chapter 16 has 26. This translation follows the Greek numbering (14 and 25 verses).

Chapter 16

The Song of Judith

[1] Judith said:

Lead off for my God with tambourines,
sing to the Lord with cymbals;
weave for him a psalm and a song of praise;
exalt him, and call upon his name.

[2] For the Lord is a God who crushes wars;[a]
he set his camp in the midst of his people
and snatched me from the hand of my pursuers.

[3] Out of the northern hills Asshur came marching,
tens of thousands strong in his might;
their host stopped up the torrent beds,
and their horsemen blanketed the hills.

[4] He vowed to set my borders ablaze,
to slay my young men with the sword,
to dash my nursing infants to the ground,
to seize my little ones as plunder
and make my maidens his spoil.

5 The Lord Almighty has thwarted them
by a woman's hand.
6 For their champion did not fall by young men's blows,
nor did sons of Titans[b] strike him down,
nor towering giants attack him;
but Judith, Merari's daughter,
undid him by the beauty of her face.
7 She stripped off her widow's robe
for the lifting up of Israel's sufferers.
With fragrant oil she smoothed her face,
8 bound up her hair with a headband,
and put on a linen gown to lead him astray.
9 Her sandal ravished his eye,
her beauty took his soul captive,
and the sword went through his neck!
10 Persians shuddered at her daring,
and Medes were dismayed at her boldness.[c]
11 Then my lowly ones shouted for joy,
and my weak ones cried aloud, and the enemy cowered;[d]
they lifted their voices, and the enemy was routed.
12 Sons of slave girls pierced them through;
they wounded them like the children of deserters.
They perished before the battle line of my Lord.
13 To my God I will raise a fresh hymn:
Lord, great are you, and full of glory,
wonderful in strength, unconquerable.
14 Let all your creation serve you,
for you spoke, and they came to be.
You sent out your spirit, and it built them;
there is none who can withstand your voice.
15 For the mountains will be shaken to their foundations, and the waters with them;
before your face the rocks will melt like wax.
But to those who fear you
you will still show mercy.

16 For every sacrifice as a fragrant aroma is a small thing,
and all the fat for burnt offerings to you a very little thing;
but the one who reveres the Lord stands great for all time.
17 Woe to the nations that rise up against my race!
On judgment day the Lord Almighty will repay them,
giving their bodies over to fire and worm,
and they will weep in pain forever.[e]
18 When they got to Jerusalem, they worshiped God. Once the people were cleansed, they presented their burnt offerings, their voluntary offerings, and their gifts. 19 Every article of Holofernes that the people had bestowed on her Judith consecrated to God; the canopy too, which she had carried off for herself from his sleeping quarters, she presented to God as a dedicated gift. 20 For three months the people continued feasting in Jerusalem before the sanctuary, and Judith stayed with them.
21 After this they all returned home, each to his own inheritance. Judith went back to Bethulia and lived on her estate, and in her time she was honored throughout the whole country. 22 Many longed to wed her, yet from the day her husband Manasseh died and was joined to his people, she never lay with a man as long as she lived. 23 Her fame went on increasing, and she grew old in the house of her husband until she was a hundred and five. Her maid she released into freedom. At Bethulia she died, and they laid her in the tomb-cave of Manasseh her husband. 24 For seven days Israel's house lamented her. While still living she had shared out her goods among all the near kin of Manasseh her husband and among her own closest relations. 25 In Judith's lifetime, and for many days after she died, there was no one to make the Israelites afraid again.[f]

Notes

- a (16:2) A God who crushes wars: so Exodus 15:3 in the Greek, "the Lord who shatters wars." The song draws on the Song of the Sea (Exodus 15) and the Song of Deborah (Judges 5).
- b (16:6) Titans: in Greek myth the Titans were the older race of gods; in the Greek Bible the word can render Hebrew Rephaim, the legendary giants (as in 2 Samuel 5:18, 22 in some Greek manuscripts).

- c (16:10) Boldness: the mention of Persians and Medes, rather than Assyrians, is one of the book's anachronisms (see the note at 1:1).
- d (16:11) Cowered: the subjects of the verbs in this verse are ambiguous in the Greek; the translation supplies "the enemy" where the sense seems to require it. Scholarly review recommended.
- e (16:17) Weep in pain forever: compare Isaiah 66:24; Sirach 7:17. This is one of the earliest expressions of eternal punishment for the wicked.
- f (16:25) Long time after her death: the Vulgate adds that the day of Judith's victory was celebrated as a festival among the Jews; this is not in the Greek.

Additions to Esther

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

Addition A: Mordecai's Dream and the Eunuchs' Plot

Greek Esther 1:1a–r (KJV Apocrypha 11:2–12:6). In the Greek book this stands before Esther 1:1.

1 It was the second regnal year of Artaxerxes the Great,[a] on the first
day of Nisan (March–April),[b] that Mordecai[c] son of Jair, son of Shimei,
son of Kish, of Benjamin's tribe, beheld a dream. 2 A Jew by birth, he
made his home in the city of Susa,[d] a man of standing who waited on
the king within his court. 3 He was one of that captive company whom
Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had carried off out of Jerusalem
along with Jeconiah king of Judea.[e] And this was his dream:
4 Behold, voices and din, thunderclaps and quaking, turmoil upon the
earth! 5 And behold, two huge dragons[f] came out, the pair of them
primed to wrestle, and from them there rose a mighty roar. 6 At that
roar every nation got itself ready for war, to wage battle on a nation
of righteous ones. 7 And behold, a day of murk and gloom, of pressure
and narrow straits, of ill-usage and vast turmoil upon the earth! 8 The
whole righteous nation was thrown into confusion; dreading the evils
laid up for them, they braced themselves to perish, and they raised
a cry to God. 9 And out of their cry, as if out of a small spring, there
came to be a great river, waters in plenty. 10 Light, and the sun came
up; the humble were raised on high and swallowed up the illustrious.
11 Mordecai, the one who had seen this dream and what God had
purposed to do, awoke; he held it fast in his heart and longed to grasp
it in its every word, until night came.
12 Now Mordecai was taking his ease in the court with Gabatha and
Tharra,[g] two of the king's eunuchs who kept watch over the court.
13 He caught their reckonings and searched out their worries, and
he learned that they were making ready to lay hands on King Artax-

erxes; so he informed the king about them. 14 The king put the two eunuchs to examination; they owned the deed and were led away.[h] 15 The king wrote these matters down for a record, and Mordecai likewise put into writing an account of them. 16 Then the king charged Mordecai to serve in the court and bestowed gifts on him in return for these things. 17 But Haman son of Hammedatha, the Bougaean,[i] enjoyed great honor in the king's sight, and he looked for a way to do harm to Mordecai and to his people because of the king's two eunuchs.[j]

Notes

- a (1:1) Artaxerxes: the Greek Esther calls the king Artaxerxes (Old Persian Artakhshaça, "whose rule is through truth," reported); the Hebrew book calls him Ahasuerus (Ahashverosh), who is generally identified with Xerxes I (486–465 BC). On that identification the second year is about 485/484 BC. Josephus likewise calls him Artaxerxes (reported).
- b (1:1) Nisan: the first month of the Jewish year, of Babylonian origin; it began at the new moon of March–April.
- c (1:1) Mordecai: Greek Mardochaios, Hebrew Mordekhai, probably a name formed from that of the Babylonian god Marduk. Jair means "he gives light," Shimei "heard," and Kish perhaps "gift" (reported); Shimei and Kish are names connected with the family of Saul (2 Samuel 16:5; 1 Samuel 9:1). Benjamin means "son of the right hand."
- d (1:2) Susa: Hebrew Shushan, a royal residence of the Persian kings in Elam, in southwest Iran. Greek "Susa the city" may mean the city as distinct from the fortified citadel (compare Esther 1:2 Hebrew), but the distinction is not certain.
- e (1:3) Jeconiah: Greek Iechonias, also called Jehoiachin ("Yahweh establishes"), deported in 597 BC (2 Kings 24:12–15). Read strictly, this would make Mordecai well over a hundred years old under Xerxes. The same difficulty arises in Hebrew Esther 2:6, where the clause may instead refer to his great-grandfather Kish.
- f (1:5) Dragons: Greek drakontes, great serpents or dragons. Mordecai explains them in Addition F (F4) as himself and Haman.
- g (1:12) Gabatha and Tharra: these are Bigthan (or Bigthana) and Teresh in Hebrew Esther 2:21. The KJV Apocrypha begins chapter 12 with this verse (A12 = KJV 12:1). The plot reported here doubles the one told in Esther 2:21–23, which the Hebrew places in the seventh year or later.
- h (1:14) Were led away: a common Greek euphemism for being taken off to execution. KJV has "strangled." In Hebrew Esther 2:23 the two are hanged (or impaled) on a stake.
- i (1:17) Haman: Greek Aman; the meaning of the name is uncertain (perhaps Persian or Elamite, reported). Hammedatha (Greek Amadathos) is a Persian name,

perhaps "given by the moon" or "given by Haoma" (reported). "Bougaean" (Greek Bougaios) is obscure; it seems to stand where the Hebrew calls him an "Agagite" (Esther 3:1), linking him with Agag the Amalekite (1 Samuel 15:8). In Addition E (E10) he is called a Macedonian. Review.

- j (1:17) Because of the king's two eunuchs: here Haman's enmity comes from the fate of the eunuchs, whereas in Esther 3:2–6 it comes from Mordecai's refusal to bow to him. The two motives stand side by side in the Greek book.

Chapter 2

Addition B: The King's Letter against the Jews

Greek Esther 3:13a–g (KJV Apocrypha 13:1–7). In the Greek book this follows Esther 3:13.

1 And of the letter this is the copy: "The Great King Artaxerxes writes thus to the governors of the hundred and twenty-seven provinces from India to Ethiopia,[a] and to the district officials set beneath them: 2 "Having become ruler over many nations and gained mastery over the whole inhabited world, I have willed, never buoyed up by the brashness of my power but ever handling affairs with fairness and mildness, to establish for my subjects lives free of every billow, to furnish a kingdom tamed and open to travel as far as its outermost limits, and to bring back that peace for which every person yearns. 3 When I put the question to my counselors how this end might be attained, Haman—one excelling among us in good sense, shown to be unwavering in his loyalty and firm in his faithfulness, and holding as his prize the second dignity of the realm— 4 made plain to us that, mingled among all the tribes over the world, there is a certain hostile people whose laws set it against every nation, a people who forever brush aside the edicts of the kings, so that the joint rule[b] which we steer without fault cannot be settled firm. 5 Since we have therefore perceived that this nation, unique among all, lies continually athwart every human being, following an alien code of living by its laws, and bearing ill will to our affairs, bringing the foulest evils to pass, so that the kingdom fails to win stability, 6 we have accordingly given orders that the persons pointed out to you in the writings of Haman—who has charge of our affairs and is a second father to us[c]—be wholly uprooted, women and children with them, by their enemies' swords,

with no compassion and no sparing, on the fourteenth of the twelfth month, Adar (February–March), of this current year,[d] [7] to the end that those who were of old, and are now, ill-disposed may in a single day go down by force to Hades,[e] and for the time hereafter leave our affairs to us steady and untroubled to the last."

Notes

- a (2:1) India to Ethiopia: the limits of the Persian empire as given in Esther 1:1. "India" is the Indus valley region; "Ethiopia" (Hebrew Cush) is the Nile land south of Egypt. Additions B and E were composed in Greek, in the ornate style of Hellenistic royal correspondence; the KJV Apocrypha prints B as 13:1–7.
- b (2:4) Joint rule: Greek synarchia, a rare word for a shared or unified government; the sense is uncertain.
- c (2:6) Second father: an honorary title for the king's chief minister; compare Genesis 45:8 and Addition E (E11).
- d (2:6) Fourteenth … Adar: the Greek text of Esther 3:7 likewise has the fourteenth, but Hebrew Esther 3:13 and Addition E (E20) have the thirteenth. Adar is the twelfth month, beginning at the new moon of February–March.
- e (2:7) Hades: Greek Hadēs, the realm of the dead, corresponding to Hebrew Sheol.

Chapter 3

Addition C: The Prayers of Mordecai and Esther

Greek Esther 4:17a–z (KJV Apocrypha 13:8–14:19). In the Greek book this follows Esther 4:17.

[1] Then Mordecai besought the Lord, recalling to mind every work of the Lord, and spoke:[a] [2] "Lord, Lord, King holding sway over all things, since the whole universe rests in your authority, and none can stand opposed to you when your will is to save Israel— [3] for it was you who made the heaven and the earth and everything to be wondered at under heaven, [4] and Lord of all are you; nor is there one who shall array himself against you, who are the Lord. [5] All things are known to you. You know, Lord, that it was not in insolence, nor in haughtiness, nor in a craving for glory that I did this, the not bowing low before the haughty Haman;[b] [6] for I would have been well content to kiss the very soles of his feet to keep Israel safe. [7] Rather, I acted so, lest I set a mortal's glory higher than God's glory; and to none will I bow low except to you, my Lord, and I will not do these things in haughtiness. [8] And now, Lord God, the King, God of Abraham,[c] have

pity on your people, for they are watching us to bring us to ruin, and they have set their hearts on destroying your inheritance from the first. 9 Do not look past your portion, which you ransomed out of the land of Egypt for your own. 10 Give ear to my plea; show mercy to your allotted share, and change our mourning into feasting, so that living we may hymn your name, Lord; and do not blot out the mouth of those who give you praise." 11 And all Israel shouted aloud with their whole strength, for their death stood before their eyes.

12 Esther the queen too, gripped by mortal anguish, fled for refuge to the Lord.[d] 13 Putting off the robes of her glory, she wrapped herself in robes of hardship and lament. Instead of costly fragrances she heaped her head with ash and filth; she brought her body very low, and every spot that her joyful adornment had graced she covered with locks of her twisted hair. 14 And she made her plea to the Lord God of Israel, saying: "My Lord, our King, you alone are he; come to my aid, who am alone and have no helper apart from you, 15 since my danger lies in my hand.[e] 16 I have heard from my birth, in the tribe of my father's house, that you, Lord, chose out Israel from among all the nations, and our fathers from all who went before them, as a possession forever, and that you performed for them whatever you had spoken. 17 But now we have done wrong before your face, and you have given us up into our enemies' grasp, 18 in return for our giving glory to their gods. Just are you, Lord! 19 And now they have not had their fill of the bitterness of our bondage; they have laid their hands on the hands of their idols,[f] 20 to cancel what your mouth decreed, to wipe out your inheritance, to block up the mouth of those who praise you, and to snuff out the glory of your house and of your altar; 21 to open the mouth of the nations to extol the virtues of vain things, and to have a king of flesh held in wonder forever. 22 Do not, Lord, hand over your scepter to things that have no being;[g] do not let them jeer at our fall, but turn their counsel back upon themselves, and make a public example of the one who began this against us. 23 Remember, Lord; reveal yourself in the hour of our distress, and put courage into me, King of the gods and Master over every power. 24 Set fitting and well-measured speech in my mouth before the lion,[h] and turn his heart to loathing of him

who makes war on us, to make an end of him and those who are of one mind with him. 25 But us, deliver by your hand, and help me, who am alone and have none but you, Lord. 26 Knowledge of everything is yours, and you know that I have hated the glory of the lawless and loathe the bed of the uncircumcised and of every foreigner.[i] 27 You know my constraint: that I loathe the emblem of my proud station that rests on my head on the days I am on display; I loathe it like a cloth of a woman's impurity,[j] and on my days of quiet I do not put it on. 28 Your slave woman has not eaten at the table of Haman, nor have I honored a banquet of the king, nor drunk wine of drink offerings.[k] 29 Since the day of my change of fortune until now your slave woman has found no gladness except in you, Lord God of Abraham. 30 O God, mighty over all, hear the voice of those who have lost hope; save us from the hand of the wicked, and save me from my fear."

Notes

- a (3:1) The Lord: Greek kyrios, used throughout these prayers, where the Hebrew book of Esther never names God at all. The KJV Apocrypha prints Mordecai's prayer as 13:8–18 (C1 = 13:8). Review.
- b (3:5) Bowing low: Greek proskynein, the bow or prostration paid to Persian kings and high officials. Mordecai explains here a refusal that the Hebrew book leaves unexplained (Esther 3:2–4).
- c (3:8) Abraham: "father of a multitude" (Genesis 17:5).
- d (3:12) Esther: Greek Esthēr, Hebrew Ester, perhaps from Persian stāra, "star," or from the name of the goddess Ishtar (reported); her Hebrew name was Hadassah, "myrtle" (Esther 2:7). The KJV Apocrypha begins chapter 14 here (C12 = 14:1).
- e (3:15) My danger lies in my hand: that is, "I am taking my life in my hands"; compare Judges 12:3 and 1 Samuel 19:5.
- f (3:19) Laid their hands on the hands of their idols: that is, they have made a solemn pledge before their gods.
- g (3:22) Things that have no being: the idols, or the false gods they represent.
- h (3:24) The lion: the king.
- i (3:26) Bed of the uncircumcised: the prayer presents Esther's marriage to the Persian king as something forced on her, answering a question the Hebrew book does not raise.
- j (3:27) A cloth of a woman's impurity: Greek rhakos katamēniōn, a menstrual cloth (compare Leviticus 15:19–24; Isaiah 64:6). The "emblem" is her royal headdress.
- k (3:28) Wine of drink offerings: wine poured out to pagan gods (compare Deuteronomy 32:38). Compare Daniel 1:8, and contrast Hebrew Esther, which says nothing about Esther keeping food laws.

Chapter 4

Addition D: Esther Goes In to the King

Greek Esther 5:1, 1a–f, 2, 2a–b (KJV Apocrypha 15:1–16). In the Greek book this takes the place of Hebrew Esther 5:1–2.

1 On the third day, when she left off praying, she laid aside the
garments of her worship[a] and arrayed herself in her splendor. 2 Then,
made radiant, she invoked God, overseer and savior of all, and took
along her two maids; 3 on the one she leaned, as a woman given to
delicate ways,[b] 4 while the other came after, bearing up her gown. 5
She herself was rosy in the full bloom of her loveliness, her face glad
as though it were loving, but her heart was pinched tight with fear. 6
Having passed through all the doors, she came to stand face to face
with the king. He was sitting upon the throne of his kingdom, robed
in all the attire of his majesty, the whole of it gold and precious stones,
and he was exceedingly fearsome. 7 Lifting his face, ablaze with glory,
he looked upon her in the full heat of wrath; the queen dropped, her
color turned as she swooned, and she sank forward over the head
of the maid going before her. 8 Then God turned the king's spirit to
mildness;[c] in anxious haste he leapt up off his throne and gathered her
into his arms till she recovered, and he soothed her with peaceable
words, saying to her: 9 "Esther, what troubles you? Your brother am
I.[d] Be of good courage; 10 by no means shall you die, for our ordinance
is a common one. Come forward."[e] 11 And lifting the golden staff he
laid it upon her neck, 12 kissed her, and said, "Talk with me." 13 Her
answer to him was: "My lord, you appeared to me like an angel of
God, and at the dread of your glory my heart was shaken.[f] 14 For you
are a marvel, my lord, and your face is brimful of graces." 15 But as
she was conversing with him, she fell down from faintness; 16 and the
king was in turmoil, and his whole retinue set about reviving her.

Notes

- a (4:1) The garments of her worship: Greek therapeia, which can mean either worship or servitude; the garments are her mourning clothes of C13.
- b (4:3) Given to delicate ways: or "as one daintily bred." The Greek pictures a lady of the court leaning on an attendant.

- c (4:8) God turned the king's spirit: this sentence states what the Hebrew book only implies; God's action is the turning point of the Greek story.
- d (4:9) Brother: an affectionate form of address; compare Song of Songs 4:9, "my sister, my bride."
- e (4:10) Our ordinance is a common one: Greek koinon to prostagma hēmōn. The sense is uncertain: perhaps "the order applies to ordinary subjects, not to you," or "our command is shared between us." Review.
- f (4:13) My lord: here Greek kyrios addresses the king, not God.

Chapter 5

Addition E: The King's Letter on Behalf of the Jews

Greek Esther 8:12a–x (KJV Apocrypha 16:1–24). In the Greek book this follows Esther 8:12.

1 Set down below is a transcript of the letter: "Artaxerxes, the Great
King, to the district rulers of the hundred and twenty-seven satrapies
stretching from India to Ethiopia, and to all who are of one mind with
our government: greeting.[a]
2 "Many who are honored over and over by the boundless generosity
of their benefactors grow the more swollen in mind; 3 and not only
do they seek to do mischief to our subjects, but, unable to carry their
glut of good things, they take in hand to scheme against their very
benefactors. 4 Not only do they root out thankfulness from among
people, but, carried away by the bragging of those who have never
tasted goodness, they imagine they will slip past the justice of God,
who sees all things always, the justice that hates evil. 5 Often, too,
the coaxing of friends who were trusted to manage affairs has made
many of those set in high office share the guilt of innocent blood and
wrapped them in disasters past remedy, 6 when such men, through
the lying sophistry of their malice, beguiled the guileless good faith of
the rulers. 7 And one may see this not so much from the more ancient
histories that we have handed down, as by looking into what has been
wickedly carried out close at hand through the plague of those who
hold power undeservingly. 8 We must take thought for the days to
come, that we may furnish the kingdom undisturbed and at peace for
all humankind, 9 making use of changes and always deciding matters
that come into view with a more reasonable response. 10 For Haman

son of Hammedatha, a Macedonian,[b] truly a stranger to Persian blood
and far removed from our kind nature, was hosted among us [11] and
met with the goodwill that we bear toward every nation, so far that
he came to be proclaimed our father and continued to be honored
with prostration by everyone, as the figure next after the royal
throne. [12] But he did not bear his high station; he set to work to strip
us of our dominion and of our breath, [13] and with tangled tricks of
deceit he begged for the ruin of Mordecai, our savior and benefactor
at all times, and of Esther, the faultless partner of our royal rule,
together with their whole nation. [14] For by these means he thought
to find us bereft and to carry over the sovereignty of the Persians to
the Macedonians. [15] We, however, find that the Jews, handed over to
obliteration by this thrice-accursed wretch,[c] are no malefactors, but
live as citizens under the most just of laws, [16] being sons of the Most
High, the most great and living God, who keeps the kingdom on its
course for us and for our ancestors in the finest condition. [17] You will
therefore do well to make no use of the documents dispatched by
Haman son of Hammedatha, [18] because the very man who devised
these things has been hung up[d] at the gates of Susa with all his house,
God, who rules over everything, having swiftly paid him back the
judgment he merited. [19] Set out the copy of this letter openly in every
place, and let the Jews follow their own customs, [20] and lend them
aid, so that they may ward off those who assail them in their time
of trouble on the thirteenth of the twelfth month, Adar (February–
March), on that same day.[e] [21] For God, who wields all power, has made
this day for them a joy, in place of ruin for the chosen race. [22] And
you too, among your named festivals, keep it as a day of note with
every kind of feasting, [23] so that now and in later times it may be
salvation for us and for the Persians who wish us well, but for those
who plot against us a remembrance of their destruction. [24] Any city
or land whatever that does not act in keeping with these orders shall
be devoured in fury by spear and fire; it shall be rendered not only
untrodden by people but most odious to beasts and birds for all time."

Notes

- a (5:1) Greeting: Greek chairein, the usual opening of a Hellenistic letter. Like Addition B, this letter was composed in Greek in an elaborate rhetorical style. The KJV Apocrypha prints it as 16:1–24 (E1 = 16:1).
- b (5:10) A Macedonian: in Addition A (A17) Haman is a "Bougaean." Calling the Persian king's enemy a Macedonian reflects the Hellenistic setting of the additions, after Alexander's conquest of Persia (331 BC). Some witnesses read differently (reported).
- c (5:15) Thrice-accursed: Greek trisalitērios, a strong term of abuse.
- d (5:18) Hung up: Greek estaurōsthai, which can mean impaled, crucified or hanged. In Hebrew Esther 7:10 Haman alone is hanged, and his ten sons are killed and hung up afterward (9:7–14).
- e (5:20) Thirteenth … Adar: compare Hebrew Esther 8:12 and 9:1. Addition B (B6) has the fourteenth. Adar began at the new moon of February–March.

Chapter 6

Addition F: The Dream Explained, and the Colophon

Greek Esther 10:3a–l (KJV Apocrypha 10:4–11:1). In the Greek book this closes the book, after Esther 10:3.

1 And Mordecai said, "From God these things have come.[a] 2 For I have
called to mind the dream I saw about these matters; not one word
of it has gone unfulfilled. 3 The little spring that turned into a river—
there was light and sun and plentiful water—the river is Esther, whom
the king wedded and made queen. 4 The two dragons are myself and
Haman. 5 The nations are those that banded together to destroy the
name of the Jews. 6 And my nation, this is Israel, who cried aloud
to God and were saved. Yes, the Lord saved his people; the Lord
delivered us out of all these evils; and God worked the signs and the
great portents such as have not occurred among the nations. 7 On
this account he appointed two lots,[b] the one for God's people and
the other for every nation; 8 and these two lots came to the hour and
the season and the day of judgment in God's presence and among all
the nations. 9 And God remembered his people and gave judgment in
favor of his inheritance. 10 So these days shall be theirs in the month
of Adar (February–March), on the fourteenth and fifteenth of that
month, with gathering and joy and gladness in God's presence, age
after age without end, among Israel his people."

11 Dated the fourth year that Ptolemy and Cleopatra reigned:[c] Dositheus,[d] who claimed to be a priest and Levite, together with Ptolemy his son, delivered the foregoing letter of Purim,[e] affirming that it was genuine and that Lysimachus son of Ptolemy, one of the residents of Jerusalem, had translated it.

Notes

- a (6:1) From God: the KJV Apocrypha prints F1–10 as 10:4–13 and the colophon (F11) as 11:1; its chapter 11 then continues with Addition A (11:2). This is why the Vulgate numbering places the dream after its interpretation.
- b (6:7) Two lots: an explanation of the name Purim, from Akkadian puru, "lot" (Esther 3:7; 9:24–26). Here the lots become symbols of God's judgment between Israel and the nations.
- c (6:11) Ptolemy and Cleopatra: several Ptolemaic kings ruled with a queen named Cleopatra, so the date is uncertain. The proposals most often made are 114/113 BC (Ptolemy IX), 78/77 BC (Ptolemy XII) and 49/48 BC (Ptolemy XIII), reported. Ptolemy means "warlike." Review.
- d (6:11) Dositheus: "gift of God." Lysimachus means "loosing of battle." This note, a colophon, vouches for the Greek translation of the book as it was brought to Egypt.
- e (6:11) Letter of Purim: the Greek has "the letter of Phrourai," apparently a form of Purim; it may refer to the whole book or to the Purim letter of Esther 9:20–32.

Wisdom of Solomon

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 Love justice, you rulers of the earth;
think of the Lord[a] with goodness,
and search for him with a sincere heart,
2 for he lets himself be found by those who do not test him,
and reveals himself to those who do not doubt him.
3 For crooked reasonings separate people from God,
and his power, when it is tested, exposes the foolish;
4 because wisdom will not enter a soul that devises evil,
nor dwell in a body held in pledge to sin.
5 For a holy spirit of discipline[b] will flee from deceit,
and will withdraw from senseless reasonings,
and will be put to shame when wrongdoing comes in.
6 For wisdom is a spirit that cherishes humanity,
yet she will not let a blasphemer go unpunished for what he says;[c]
for God observes his inmost feelings,[d]
watches his heart truly,
and listens to his tongue.
7 Because the spirit of the Lord has filled the inhabited world,
and that which holds all things together has knowledge of every voice.
8 Therefore no one who utters unjust things will escape notice,
nor will Justice,[e] when she convicts, pass him by.
9 For the schemes of the ungodly will be investigated,
and news of what they say will reach the Lord,
to convict them of their lawless acts;
10 because a jealous ear hears all things,
and the murmur of grumbling is not hidden.

11 So protect yourselves from pointless complaining,
and keep your tongues from slander;
for no whispered word is without consequence,[f]
and a deceitful mouth kills the soul.
12 Do not court death by the error of your life,
nor draw destruction on yourselves by the works of your hands;
13 because God did not make death,
and he takes no delight in the destruction of the living.
14 He made everything so that it could exist,
the creatures[g] of the world are health-giving,
there is no deadly poison in them,
and Hades has no dominion[h] on earth.
15 For justice is immortal.[i]
16 But the ungodly invited death with their hands and words;[j]
they thought of it as a friend and pined away,
and they struck a pact with it,
since they deserve to be among its possessions.

Notes

- a (1:1) Greek kyrios, "Lord," the Septuagint's usual rendering of the divine name YHWH; this translation keeps "Lord" in the Greek books. The opening address "you who judge the earth" echoes Ps 2:10.
- b (1:5) Or "of instruction"; Greek paideia, training or correction. Some manuscripts (as reported, Sinaiticus) read "of wisdom."
- c (1:6) Greek "from his lips."
- d (1:6) Greek "his kidneys," thought of as the seat of the emotions.
- e (1:8) Greek dikē, justice personified as an avenging power.
- f (1:11) Or "goes unpunished"; Greek "will not go empty."
- g (1:14) Or "the creatures," "the things that come into being"; Greek geneseis.
- h (1:14) Or "palace," "dominion"; Greek basileion.
- i (1:15) The Latin tradition adds a further line, "but injustice is the acquisition of death," which is not in the Greek manuscripts used here.
- j (1:16) That is, death.

Chapter 2

1 For, reckoning wrongly, they said to themselves,
"Brief and full of grief is this life of ours,

and for a mortal's end there is no cure,
nor is anyone known who has come back[a] out of Hades.
2 For we were born by sheer accident,
and after this we will be as if we had never existed;
the breath in our nostrils is a puff of smoke,
and thought is a spark struck by our pulsing heart;
3 when it is put out, the body will turn to ashes,
and the spirit will be scattered like thin air.
4 In time our name will be forgotten,
and nobody will recall what we did;
our lives will vanish like the remnants of a cloud,
and disperse like fog
driven off by the sun's beams
and pressed down by its warmth.
5 For our allotted time is the passing of a shadow,
and there is no going back from our end,
because it is sealed up and no one turns it back.
6 "Come, then, let us enjoy the good things that are present,
and make use of the creation[b] eagerly, as in youth.
7 With wine of great price and with perfumes let us be filled,
and let no blossom of spring[c] get by us.
8 Let us crown ourselves with rosebuds before they wither.
9 Let none of us go without his share in our revelry;
everywhere let us leave tokens of our merriment,
because this is our portion, and this our lot.
10 Let us oppress the poor man who is just;
let us not spare the widow,
nor respect the gray hairs of the aged, many in years.
11 But let our strength be our law of justice,
for what is weak proves itself useless.
12 "Let us lie in wait for the just man, because he is inconvenient to us,
and he opposes our deeds;
he reproaches us for sins against the law,
and charges us with sins against our training.

13 He claims to possess knowledge of God,
and names himself a son[d] of the Lord.
14 He has become to us a reproof of our thoughts;
he is a burden to us even to look at,
15 because his life is unlike that of others,
and his paths are of another kind.
16 We are counted by him as something counterfeit,
and he keeps away from our ways as from uncleanness;
he calls the last end of the just happy,
and boasts that God is his father.
17 Let us find out whether what he says is true,
and make trial of how things go with him when he departs.
18 For if the just man is God's son, he will help him,
and will rescue him from the hand of his adversaries.
19 Let us examine him with insult and torture,
so that we may know his gentleness,
and put his forbearance to the proof.
20 Let us condemn him to a shameful death,
for, according to his words, he will be watched over."[e]
21 Thus they reasoned, and they were led astray,
for their wickedness blinded them,
22 They had no knowledge of God's hidden counsels,[f]
they set no hope on the payment due to holiness,
and they did not judge that spotless souls have a reward of honor;
23 for God created humankind for incorruption,
and made it the image of his own eternity;[g]
24 but death entered the world through the devil's[h] jealousy,
and those on his side experience it.

Notes

- a (2:1) Or "to release anyone."
- b (2:6) Or "of created things."
- c (2:7) Some manuscripts read "flower of the air"; others "flower of life."
- d (2:13) Or "servant"; Greek pais can mean either.
- e (2:20) Literally "for there will be a visitation of him according to his words."
- f (2:22) Greek mystēria, "mysteries."

- g (2:23) Some manuscripts read "of his own nature" (Greek idiotētos for aidiotētos), as reported.
- h (2:24) Greek diabolos, "slanderer," here commonly understood of the serpent of Gen 3.

Chapter 3

1 But the souls of the just are in the hand of God,
and no torment will ever[a] touch them.
2 In the eyes of the foolish they seemed to have died,
and their departure was reckoned an affliction,
3 and their going from us a ruin;
but they are at peace.
4 For though in the sight of people they were punished,
their hope is full of immortality.
5 After a small correction they will receive great blessings,
for God tried them and judged them fit for himself;
6 like gold in the furnace he tried them,
and like a whole burnt offering[b] he accepted them.
7 In the time of their visitation they will shine out,
and they will run like sparks through stubble.
8 Nations they shall judge, over peoples they shall hold sway,
and over them the Lord shall be king to the ages.
9 Whoever has put trust in him shall come to understand what is true,
and those faithful in love shall remain beside him,
for favor and mercy belong to those he has chosen.[c]
10 But the ungodly will receive punishment as their reasonings deserve,
those who disregarded the just[d] and rebelled against the Lord;
11 for whoever despises wisdom and discipline is miserable;
their hope is empty, their labors unprofitable,
and their works useless.
12 Their wives are foolish, and their children evil;
cursed is their offspring.

13 Blessed is the childless woman who is pure,
who has never shared a bed in sin;
she will bear fruit at the visitation of souls.
14 Blessed too the eunuch who has worked no lawless thing with his hand
nor plotted evil things against the Lord;
to him a chosen gift shall be given for his fidelity,
and in the Lord's sanctuary a portion all the more delightful.
15 For good toil yields a fruit of glory,
and the root of good sense never gives way.
16 But the children of adulterers will never mature,
and the offspring of an illicit union will disappear.
17 Even if they live long, they will be counted as nothing,
and at the last their old age will be without honor.
18 Should they die quickly, hope is not theirs,
nor any comfort in the day when the verdict is given.[e]
19 For hard is the end of an unrighteous generation.

Notes

- a (3:1) The Greek uses an emphatic double negative.
- b (3:6) Greek holokarpōma, a sacrifice wholly consumed on the altar.
- c (3:9) Some manuscripts add "and he watches over his holy ones," as at 4:15.
- d (3:10) Or "what is just."
- e (3:18) Greek "of decision," that is, of the verdict.

Chapter 4

1 Childlessness joined to virtue is better,
for in remembering virtue[a] there is deathlessness,
since both with God and among mortals it is recognized.
2 While it is here, people copy it;
once gone, they long for it;
and through the age it walks in procession wearing the crown,
victor in the contest whose prizes carry no stain.
3 But the fertile families of the ungodly will be useless;
grown from illegitimate cuttings, they will not root deeply
or stand firmly.

4 Though for a season they may sprout in branches,
yet, set unsteadily, they will be rocked by the wind
and torn up by the roots under the gales' force.
5 Their shoots will be snapped off unfinished,
their fruit worthless,
unripe for food, fit for nothing at all.
6 For children born of unlawful unions[b]
are witnesses of wickedness against their parents when they are examined.
7 But the just, though he come to his end early, will be at rest.
8 For honorable old age is not that of long time,
nor is it measured by number of years;
9 but understanding is gray hair for human beings,
and a spotless life is ripe old age.
10 Being pleasing to God, he was loved,
and while living among sinners he was taken up.[c]
11 He was snatched away so that evil might not alter his understanding
or guile deceive his soul.
12 For the bewitching of trivial things obscures what is good,
and the roving of desire perverts an innocent mind.
13 Made complete in a brief span, he filled out lengthy times;
14 for his soul was pleasing to the Lord;
therefore he hurried him[d] out of the midst of wickedness.
But the peoples saw and did not understand,
nor did they take such a thing to heart,
15 that grace and mercy are with his chosen ones,
and he watches over his holy ones.
16 A righteous person who has died will judge the living ungodly,
and a youth swiftly made complete will judge the long old age of the unrighteous.
17 They will look on the wise man's death
without grasping what the Lord intended for him
or why he set him in safety.

18 They will look on and sneer,
but the Lord will mock them.
19 After that they will become dishonored corpses,
an object of abuse among the dead for ages;
for he will dash them down speechless, headfirst,
and shake them from their bases;
they will be left utterly desolate to the end,
they will be in anguish,
and all memory of them will perish.
20 Cowering, they will come to the counting of their sins,
and their own lawless acts will stand opposite and accuse them.

Notes

- a (4:1) Greek "of it."
- b (4:6) Greek "of lawless sleep."
- c (4:10) Greek metetethē, the word used of Enoch in Gen 5:24 (Septuagint).
- d (4:14) Or "it hurried"; the subject may be the soul.

Chapter 5

1 Then the righteous one will take his stand with much boldness
facing those who afflicted him
and who set his toils at nothing.
2 At the sight they will be thrown into turmoil by a terrible fear
and stand astonished at a deliverance beyond all expectation.
3 Repenting, they will say to one another,
and groan through distress of spirit:
4 "This is the man we used to laugh at,
whom we made a proverb of scorn — senseless that we were!
His way of life we counted lunacy,
and his death a dishonor.
5 How has he been numbered among the children[a] of God,
and his lot is among the holy ones?
6 We wandered, then, from the road of truth;
the light of righteousness never shone for us,
and for us the sun never rose.

7 We were glutted on lawless and ruinous tracks;
we went through deserts with no road;
the Lord's way we never knew.
8 What did our arrogance profit us?
And what good has wealth, with our boasting, brought us?
9 "All those things have passed away like a shadow,
and like a rumor that runs by;
10 like a ship that passes through the surging water,
and when it has gone through, no trace of it can be found,
no track of its keel in the waves;
11 or as with a bird darting through the air:
no mark of its course is to be found,
but the slight breeze, whipped by the stroke of its feathers
and split by its whirring force,
is crossed by its beating wings,
and afterward nothing in it shows that it went that way;
12 or as, when an arrow is shot at a target,
the air, cut through, at once closes up again,
so that no one knows its pathway.
13 So it is with us: no sooner were we born than we ceased to exist,
and we had no mark of virtue to display,
but were used up in our wickedness."
14 For the hope of the ungodly is like chaff[b] carried by the wind,
and like fine frost[c] driven away by a storm;
it is scattered like smoke before the wind,
and it passes like the memory of a guest who stays a single day.
15 But the righteous live to the age,
in the Lord is their recompense,
and the Most High takes thought for them.
16 Therefore they will receive a majestic kingdom
and a beautiful crown from the Lord's hand,
for he will cover them with his right hand
and protect them with his arm.
17 He will take his zeal as his full armor,
and will arm creation to repel his enemies;

18 he will put on justice as a breastplate,
and wear impartial judgment as a helmet;
19 he will take holiness as an invincible shield,
20 he will whet unbending anger into a blade,
and the world[d] will go to war at his side against those who have lost their senses.
21 Well-aimed shafts of lightning will fly,
and as from a well-drawn bow of clouds they will leap to the target,
22 and hailstones full of fury will be shot as from a sling;
the sea's water will rage against them,
and rivers will flood over them without mercy;
23 a blast of might[e] will stand up against them
and scatter them like a whirlwind winnowing grain.
So lawlessness will turn the whole earth to desert,
and ill-doing will topple the seats of the powerful.

Notes

- a (5:5) Greek "sons"; the "holy ones" may be angels.
- b (5:14) Greek chnous, fine down or dust.
- c (5:14) Some manuscripts read "spider's web" (Greek arachnē for pachnē), as reported.
- d (5:20) Greek kosmos, "the world."
- e (5:23) Or "a spirit of power."

Chapter 6

1 Listen, therefore, you kings, and understand;
learn, you judges of the ends of the earth.
2 Give ear, you who rule over multitudes,
and who take pride in throngs of nations.
3 For your authority came to you from the Lord,
and your rule from the Most High,
who will examine what you do and scrutinize your plans.
4 For though you were ministers of his reign, you gave no upright judgment,
you did not guard the law,
and you did not walk by God's design.

5 Fearfully and fast he will stand over you,
since on those who stand high a sharp judgment comes.
6 The least may be forgiven out of pity,
but the strong will be strongly examined.
7 For the Master of all does not back away before anyone,
and is not impressed by rank,
since he made small and great alike,
and cares for them all equally.
8 For the mighty a stern scrutiny lies ahead.
9 To you, then, O sovereigns, my words are addressed,
so that you may learn wisdom and not fall away.
10 For those who keep holy things in holiness will be made holy,
and those who have been taught them will find a defense.
11 Therefore set your desire on my words;
long for them, and you will be instructed.
12 Wisdom is bright and never fades,
readily noticed by those who love her,
and discovered by those who look for her.
13 She is quick to be recognized by those who long for her, coming to meet them first.
14 Whoever rises early to seek her will not grow weary,
for he will find her sitting at his gates.
15 To think upon her is the perfection of understanding,
and whoever keeps vigil for her sake will soon be free from care,
16 For she herself goes round looking for those who deserve her;
she shows herself to them kindly along their roads
and comes to meet them in every purpose of theirs.
17 Her starting point is the truest longing for discipline;
and care for discipline is love;
18 and love of her is the keeping of her laws,
and attention to her laws is assurance of incorruption,
19 and incorruption brings one near to God;
20 Thus the longing for wisdom raises one up to royal rule.[a]

21 If, then, you delight in thrones and scepters, O sovereigns of peoples,
honor wisdom, so that you may reign for ever.
22 What wisdom is and how she came to be I will declare,
and I will not hide secret things from you,
but I will trace her out from the beginning of creation,
and bring the knowledge of her into the open,
and I will not pass by the truth;
23 nor will I travel in company with wasting envy,
for envy has no fellowship with wisdom.
24 A host of the wise keeps the world safe,
and a prudent king is the steadiness of a people.
25 Therefore be instructed by my words, and you will profit.

Notes

- a (6:20) Verses 17–20 form a chain argument (sorites), each clause taking up the last word of the one before.

Chapter 7

1 I too am mortal, like everyone,
a descendant of the earth-born first-formed one;[a]
and in a mother's womb I was sculpted into flesh,
2 within a period of ten months,[b] curdled in blood
from a man's seed and the pleasure that comes with sleep.
3 And when I was born, I too drew in the common air
and fell upon the earth that suffers alike for all;
my first sound, like that of all, was a cry.
4 I was nursed in swaddling clothes and with cares.
5 For no king has had any other beginning of existence;
6 there is for all one entrance into life, and a like departure.
7 Therefore I prayed, and understanding was granted me;
I called upon God, and a spirit of wisdom came to me.
8 I preferred her before scepters and thrones,
and wealth I held as nothing beside her.
9 Nor did I liken any priceless gem to her,
for all gold in her sight is a little sand,
and silver will be counted as clay before her.

10 Beyond health and good looks I loved her,
and I chose to have her rather than light,
because the radiance that comes from her never sleeps.
11 Together with her all good things came to me,
and in her hands wealth past counting.
12 Over all of them I was glad, since wisdom goes at their head,
though I was unaware that she was the one who bore[c] them.
13 Without guile I learned, and without grudging I share;
I do not hide away her riches;
14 for she is an unfailing treasure for human beings;
those who make use of it gain friendship with God,
commended by the gifts that come from instruction.
15 May God grant me to speak as he would have it,[d]
and to think thoughts worthy of what has been given me,
for he is himself the guide even of wisdom,
and the one who sets the wise aright.
16 For in his hand are both we ourselves and our sayings,
and all good sense and the know-how of the crafts.
17 He himself gave me true knowledge of the things that are:
to know how the universe is put together and how its elements act;
18 the beginning and end and middle of times,
the shifts of the solstices[e] and the changes of the seasons,
19 the cycles of years and the positions of the stars,
20 the nature of animals and the moods of wild beasts,
the power of spirits[f] and the thoughts of people,
the kinds of plants and the properties of roots;
21 whatever is hidden and whatever is manifest I learned,
for wisdom, the artisan of all things, taught me.
22 For there is in her a spirit, thinking and holy,
only-begotten, many-sided, fine,
quick to move, distinct, unsoiled,
plain, unharmed, fond of the good, sharp,
23 unhindered, beneficent, humane,
steadfast, sure, free from care,

all-powerful, overseeing all,
and passing through all spirits
that are intelligent, pure, and most subtle.[g]
24 For wisdom is more mobile than any motion;
because of her purity she pervades and penetrates all things.
25 For she is a vapor of the power of God,
and an unalloyed outflow of the glory of the Almighty;[h]
therefore nothing defiled finds its way into her.
26 For she is a reflected radiance of everlasting light,
a spotless mirror of the working of God,
and an image of his goodness.
27 One, she has power for everything;
abiding in herself, she makes everything new;
and age after age, crossing into devout souls,
she fashions friends of God and prophets.
28 For God loves nothing except the one who lives together with wisdom.
29 For she is lovelier than the sun,
and above every arrangement of stars;
set beside light, she is found ahead of it;
30 for night succeeds to it,
but against wisdom evil does not prevail.

Notes

- a (7:1) That is, Adam.
- b (7:2) Ten lunar months, about nine calendar months.
- c (7:12) Greek genesin, "origin" or "begetter"; some manuscripts read genetin, "mother."
- d (7:15) Or "to speak with judgment."
- e (7:18) Greek tropōn, "turnings," the turning points of the sun's course.
- f (7:20) Or "winds."
- g (7:23) Verses 22–23 list twenty-one attributes (3 × 7), a number of perfection.
- h (7:25) Greek pantokratōr, "ruler of all."

Chapter 8

1 From end to end she stretches out in strength,
and she manages the whole well.

2 Her I loved and sought out from my youth;
I sought to take her as a bride for myself,
and became a lover of her beauty.
3 She proclaims her noble birth by living with God,
and the Master of all loved her.
4 For she is an initiate in the knowledge of God,
and one who chooses among his works.
5 If riches are a possession to be desired in life,
what is richer than wisdom, who works all things?
6 And if understanding is at work,
who more than she is the artisan of what exists?
7 Does someone love righteousness?
The fruit of her toils is the virtues;
for she teaches moderation and good sense,
righteousness and manliness;[a]
and for mortals in this life there is nothing more profitable than these.
8 Does someone long for much experience?
She knows the ancient things and guesses the coming ones;
she knows the twists of sayings and how riddles are untied;
signs and portents she knows in advance,
and how the seasons and the ages turn out.
9 So I resolved to bring her home to live with me,
knowing she would advise me well
and comfort me in worry and sorrow.
10 Through her I will gain fame among crowds
and respect from the elders, young as I am.
11 Sharp I shall be found in giving judgment,
and before the powerful I shall be a marvel.
12 When I am quiet they will wait on me,
and when I speak they will pay attention,
and if I go on talking, they will put hands over their mouths.
13 Through her I shall possess deathlessness,
and I shall leave to those who come after me a memory that lasts for ever.

14 I shall order the affairs of peoples,
and nations shall be made subject to me.
15 Fearsome tyrants will be afraid when they hear of me;
I will prove kind toward the people, and brave in battle.
16 Entering my house I shall take my rest beside her,
for there is no bitterness in her company,
no pain in living with her, but good cheer and joy.
17 Turning these things over within myself,
and weighing them in my heart,
that deathlessness lies in being akin to wisdom,
18 and good delight in her friendship,
and in the toils of her hands riches that do not run out,
and good sense in practice at her side,
and fair fame in taking part in her words,
I went all around searching how I might take her for my own.
19 I was a child of good nature,
and a good soul fell to my lot;
20 or rather, being good, I entered an undefiled body.[b]
21 But perceiving that I would not otherwise gain possession of her unless God gave her —
and it was a mark of understanding to know whose gift she was —
I appealed to the Lord and implored him,
and with my whole heart I said:

Notes

- a (8:7) The four cardinal virtues of Greek philosophy.
- b (8:20) The verse reflects the Greek idea of the soul's existence before the body; verse 19 states it the other way.

Chapter 9

1 "God of the fathers and Lord of mercy,
who made all things by your word,
2 and by your wisdom formed humankind
to have dominion over the creatures that came into being by you,
3 and to govern the world in holiness and justice,
and to pronounce judgment in uprightness of soul,

4 grant me the wisdom that shares the seat of your thrones,
and do not reject me from among your children.[a]
5 For I am your slave and your slave-girl's son,
a weak human being, of brief time,
and too slight for understanding of right and of laws;
6 for even if one is perfect among the children of men,
yet without the wisdom that comes from you he will be counted as nothing.
7 It was you who picked me as king of your people
and as judge of your sons and your daughters.
8 You ordered me to build a sanctuary on your holy mountain,
and an altar in the city where you make your dwelling,
a replica of the sacred tent you prepared long ago.
9 Wisdom is with you; she knows what you do
and was there when you created the world,
she grasps what pleases you
and what accords with your commands.
10 Send her forth from the holy heavens,
and from the throne of your glory dispatch her,
that she may be with me and labor with me,
and that I may learn what is pleasing to you.
11 For she knows all things and has insight into them,
and in what I do she will lead me with good sense
and keep watch over me by her glory.
12 And my deeds shall be acceptable,
and I shall judge your people righteously,
and be worthy of my father's throne.[b]
13 "For what human being can learn the counsel of God?
Or who can conceive what the Lord wills?
14 For the reasonings of mortals are timid,
and our designs are likely to fail;
15 for a perishable body weighs down the soul,
and this earthly tent burdens the mind that ponders many things.

16 Even what is on earth we picture with difficulty,
and what lies in our hands we discover with toil;
but the things in the heavens, who has tracked them down?
17 Who has learned your counsel, unless you gave wisdom
and sent your holy spirit from on high?
18 So it was that the ways of earth's dwellers were made straight,
and human beings learned the things that please you,
and through wisdom they were brought to safety."

Notes

- a (9:4) Or "servants"; Greek paides.
- b (9:12) Greek "thrones," a plural of majesty.

Chapter 10

1 She it was who guarded the father of the world, the first to be shaped,
when he had been created alone,
and drew him out of his own fall,
2 and gave him strength to rule over all things.
3 But when one who was unjust[a] turned from her in his anger,
he was destroyed together with the brother-killing rage he gave way to.
4 And when because of him the earth was drowned, wisdom saved it once more,
piloting the righteous one[b] on a cheap timber.
5 She too, when the nations were thrown into confusion in their unanimity of wickedness,[c]
knew the righteous one[d] and kept him faultless before God
and held him firm against his tender feeling for his child.
6 She rescued a just man[e] when the ungodly were perishing;
he fled from the fire that came down on the Five Cities.
7 To their evil there still bears witness
a smoking land left waste,
and plants that bear fruit not brought to its time,
and, standing as a memorial of a soul without faith, a pillar of salt.
8 For they walked past wisdom
and so were not merely harmed by not knowing what is good,

but also left to the living a monument to their senselessness,
that what they stumbled in might not escape notice.
9 Wisdom rescued from troubles those who served her.
10 She guided a righteous one[f] along straight paths
when he fled from the anger of his brother;
she let him see God's kingdom,
she gave him the knowledge of holy things,
she made him thrive in his hard work
and multiplied what his labors produced.
11 In the greed of those who overpowered him she stood at his side
and gave him wealth.
12 From his foes she kept him,
and from those lying in ambush she made him safe;
and a stiff contest she awarded to him,[g]
that he might know that reverence for God is stronger than all.
13 When a just man[h] was sold, she did not abandon him,
but rescued him from sin.
14 She descended with him into the pit,
and did not abandon him in his chains,
until she delivered to him a royal scepter
and power over those who had oppressed him;
she exposed his accusers as liars,
and granted him lasting glory.
15 A holy people and a blameless offspring
she delivered from a nation of oppressors.
16 Into the soul of the Lord's attendant[i] she went,
and she stood up to fearsome kings with portents and signs.
17 To the holy ones she paid out the reward of their toil;
she led them on a wonderful road,
and she was for them a covering in the day
and a blaze of stars all night.
18 She brought them over the Red Sea,
and led them through deep waters;
19 but their enemies she drowned,
and cast them up from the depth of the abyss.

20 So the righteous carried off spoil from the ungodly,
and they hymned, Lord, your holy name,
and with one heart they praised your hand that fought for them;
21 for wisdom opened the mouths of the mute,
and made the tongues of infants speak clearly.

Notes

- a (10:3) Cain (Gen 4). Throughout chapters 10–19 the biblical figures are not named.
- b (10:4) Noah (Gen 6–9).
- c (10:5) At Babel (Gen 11).
- d (10:5) Abraham (Gen 12–22; for the child, Gen 22).
- e (10:6) Lot (Gen 19). The "Five Cities" (Greek Pentapolis) are those of Gen 14:2.
- f (10:10) Jacob (Gen 27–31).
- g (10:12) Jacob's wrestling at the Jabbok (Gen 32).
- h (10:13) Joseph (Gen 37–41).
- i (10:16) Moses.

Chapter 11

1 She prospered their works by the hand of a holy prophet.
2 Through a desert where no one lived they made their way,
and in places with no path they set up their tents.
3 They took a stand against those at war with them and beat back their enemies.
4 They were thirsty and called on you,
and from a sheer cliff water was given them,
and from hard rock relief from thirst.
5 For by the very means through which their foes were chastised,
by these, when they were at a loss, they received benefit.[a]
6 In place of a river's ever-running spring
churned with gore and filth[b]
7 as a reproof of the order to murder the babies,
you gave them plenty of water when they had no hope of it,
8 making plain by the thirst they then felt
in what manner you chastised their opponents.
9 For when they were put to the test, though they were being corrected with mercy,
they learned how the ungodly suffered when judged with anger.

10 For you tested them as a father does in warning,
but you examined the others as a stern king does in condemnation.
11 Whether absent or present, they were equally distressed,
12 for double sorrow gripped them,
and they moaned as they remembered the past.
13 For when they heard that through their own punishments
the others had been benefited, they perceived the Lord.
14 For the one whom long before they had cast out and exposed[c]
and then rejected with scorn,
him they admired at the end of the events,
having thirsted in a way unlike the just.
15 As repayment for their foolish and wicked reasoning,
which misled them into worshiping mindless snakes and contemptible animals,[d]
you sent a horde of mindless beasts against them as punishment,
16 so they would know that the instruments of someone's sin are the instruments of his punishment.
17 For your almighty hand,
which fashioned the world from shapeless matter,
had no shortage of ways to send a horde of bears or fierce lions against them,
18 or newly created unknown beasts full of rage,
either breathing out fiery breath,
or belching thick smoke,
or flashing terrible sparks from their eyes;
19 not only could their harm destroy them utterly,
but even the very sight of them could kill by fright.
20 Even without these, they could have been felled by one breath,
hunted down by justice
and blown away by your mighty spirit.
But you have ordered everything by measure, number, and weight.
21 For great might is ever at your side,
and the strength of your arm, who shall stand against it?

22 The whole universe before you is like the small weight that turns a balance,[e]
and like a dewdrop at dawn coming down to the ground.
23 But you are merciful to all, because you can do everything,
and you pass over human sins so that people may repent.
24 For you love all things that exist,
and loathe none of the things you have made;
for you would never have formed anything if you had hated it.
25 How would anything remain if you did not wish it?
Or what you had not called, how would it be kept?
26 You spare all things, because they are yours, O Master, lover of souls.[f]

Notes

- a (11:5) The theme of chapters 11–19: the same elements that punished Egypt benefited Israel.
- b (11:6) The first plague (Exod 7:14–24).
- c (11:14) Moses as an infant (Exod 1:22–2:3).
- d (11:15) Egyptian animal worship.
- e (11:22) Compare Isa 40:15.
- f (11:26) Or "lover of life."

Chapter 12

1 For your incorruptible spirit is in all things.
2 So those who slip you reprove bit by bit,
and in the things where they go wrong you remind and admonish them,
that they may be set free from evil and put their trust, Lord, in you.
3 For the ancient dwellers in your holy land[a]
4 you hated, because they practiced hateful deeds,
acts of witchcraft and impious rites,
5 pitiless killers of children
and devourers at banquets of men's flesh and of blood.
Initiates out of the midst of a frenzied band,[b]
6 and parents who slaughtered souls that had no helper,
you resolved to wipe out by our fathers' hands,

7 so that the land most precious of all in your sight
might receive a worthy colony of God's children.[c]
8 Yet even these, as human beings, you spared;
you sent hornets[d] ahead of your host
to make an end of them by degrees,
9 not that you could not hand the ungodly over to the righteous in a battle line,
or rub them out all together through terrible beasts or a harsh word;
10 But by judging them gradually you gave them time to repent,
though you knew well that their origin was wicked,
their evil was inborn,
and their thinking would never change.
11 For their seed was cursed from the start,[e]
nor was it out of fear of anyone that you granted impunity for what they did wrong.
12 For who shall say, "What did you do?"
Or who shall stand up against your sentence?
Who shall charge you over nations destroyed that you yourself had made?
Or who shall come and stand against you as pleader for unrighteous men?
13 There is no god but you, who cares for all,
that you should show him your verdicts were not unjust;
14 nor shall king or tyrant be able to look you in the face
on behalf of those you have punished.
15 Being righteous, you order all things righteously,
and you judge it foreign to your might
to pass sentence on one who ought not to be chastised.
16 For your strength is the source of justice,
and your sovereignty over all causes you to spare all.
17 For you display strength when someone doubts that your power is complete,
and among those who do know it you put boldness to shame.

18 But you, master of strength, judge with gentleness,
and with great sparing you govern us;
for the power is at hand for you whenever you will.
19 By such deeds you taught your people
that the righteous man must be a lover of humankind,
and you made your sons to be of good hope,
that for sins you grant a change of mind.
20 For if the enemies of your children, who were owed death,
you punished with such heed and such pardon,
giving them times and room in which to be rid of evil,
21 with what exactness you have judged your own sons,
to whose fathers you gave oaths and covenants of good pledges!
22 So while you discipline us, you strike our enemies ten thousand times harder,
so that we think of your goodness when we judge,
and expect mercy when we ourselves are judged.
23 So those who lived unjustly and foolishly
you tormented with their own abominations.
24 For they wandered very far along the roads of going astray,
taking for gods the most worthless and dishonored of animals,
fooled the way infants are who have no sense.
25 And so, as on children without reason,
you sent a judgment that made sport of them.
26 But those not set right by playful rebukes of correction
shall find a judgment worthy of God.
27 For in the very things that made them suffer and chafe,
in the things they counted gods and by which they were punished,
they saw and acknowledged as true God him whom they had refused to know before;
and so the utmost sentence came down on them.

Notes

- a (12:3) The Canaanites.
- b (12:5) The Greek of verses 5–6 is difficult and the text may be corrupt.
- c (12:7) Or "servants."
- d (12:8) Or "hornets" (Exod 23:28; Deut 7:20).

• e (12:11) Compare the curse of Canaan, Gen 9:25.

Chapter 13

1 For by nature all people were futile in whom ignorance of God was present,
and from the good things that are seen they had no strength to know Him Who Is,[a]
nor, paying heed to the works, did they recognize the craftsman;
2 but either fire or wind or swift air,
or the circle of the stars or rushing water
or the lights of heaven, governors of the world, they took for gods.
3 If, delighted by their beauty, they supposed these to be gods,
let them know how much better than these is their Master,
for the first author of beauty created them;
4 and if they were struck with wonder at their power and working,
let them perceive from these how much more powerful is the one who formed them.
5 For from the greatness and beauty of created things
their Maker is seen by analogy.[b]
6 Yet on these people the blame is slight,
for perhaps they go astray
while seeking God and wanting to find him;
7 for, living among his works, they search,
and they are won over by the sight, because what they see is beautiful.
8 But again, not even they are to be pardoned;
9 for if they had power to know so much
that they could make a guess at the age,[c]
how did they not sooner find the Master of these things?
10 But wretched, with their hopes in dead things, are those
who called the works of human hands gods,
gold and silver, worked with skill, and likenesses of living things,
or a useless stone, the work of an ancient hand.
11 Suppose a woodcutter saws down a tree easy to handle,
skillfully strips off all its bark,

and, shaping it handsomely,
makes a useful vessel for the service of life,
12 and burns the leftovers of his work
to cook his food and eat his fill;
13 and the leftover from these, good for nothing,
a crooked stick grown full of knots,
he takes and carves with the care of his idle hours,
and shapes it with the experience of his leisure;[d]
he forms it into the image of a man,
14 or likens it to some worthless creature,
smearing it with red ochre and painting its surface red with paint,
and covering every blemish in it;
15 then, making for it a dwelling worthy of it,
he sets it in the wall and fastens it with iron.
16 So he takes thought for it that it may not fall,
knowing that it cannot help itself,
for it is an image and needs help.
17 When he prays for his property, his marriage, and his children,
he feels no shame addressing something lifeless;
for health he appeals to something feeble,
18 for life he begs what is dead,
for aid he entreats what is utterly inexperienced,
for a journey what cannot use its feet,
19 and for getting and working and good fortune in the use of his hands
he begs strong handiness of the thing most helpless in its hands.

Notes

- a (13:1) Greek ton onta, "the one who is," echoing the Septuagint of Exod 3:14.
- b (13:5) Greek analogōs, "correspondingly."
- c (13:9) Greek aiōn, here perhaps "the universe."
- d (13:13) Some manuscripts read "with the skill of understanding." Compare Isa 44:9–20.

Chapter 14

1 Again, someone preparing to sail and about to cross the wild waves
calls upon a piece of wood more rotten than the vessel that carries him.

2 For that boat was thought up by the craving for profit,
and wisdom as craftswoman put it together;
3 but it is your providence, Father, that steers it,
because you have given it a way even in the sea
and a safe path among the waves,
4 showing that you can save from every danger,
so that even one without skill may go aboard.
5 It is your will that the works of your wisdom should not be idle;
therefore people entrust their lives even to the smallest timber,
and passing through the surge on a raft they are brought safely through.
6 For at the start too, as the proud giants were being destroyed,[a]
the world's hope fled for refuge on a raft
and, piloted by your hand, bequeathed to the age a seed of new birth.
7 For blessed is the wood through which righteousness comes;[b]
8 but the handmade thing is accursed, both it and the one who made it —
he, because he worked it, and the perishable thing, because it was named a god.
9 For hated alike by God are the impious and his impiety;
10 For the deed done shall be chastised along with its doer.
11 So on the idols of the nations too there shall come a visitation,
since among the things God made they turned into a loathsome thing,
traps for human souls
and a noose for the feet of fools.
12 For the devising of idols was the beginning of fornication,[c]
and their invention the corruption of life;
13 For they were not there at the start,
and they shall not remain to the age;
14 For through the empty conceit of human beings they entered the world,
and therefore a speedy end has been planned for them.

15 For a father, consumed with untimely grief
for a child suddenly taken from him,
made an image of him,
and now honored as a god one who was once a dead human being,
and handed on to those under him mysteries and initiations.
16 Then, strengthened by time, the impious habit was guarded as if it were law,
and by order of tyrants the carved figures received worship.
17 When people could not honor kings face to face, since they lived far away,
they imagined the king's likeness from a distance
and made a visible statue of the king they revered,
so that in their eagerness they could flatter the absent king as if he were there.
18 And to heighten the cult even among those who did not know him,
the craftsman's love of distinction pushed them on.
19 For he, wishing perhaps to gratify the man in power,
used his art to force the likeness into something finer;
20 and the crowd, drawn in by the charm of the workmanship,
now reckoned as an object of reverence the one they had a little earlier honored as a man.
21 And this became a hidden trap for life,[d]
because people, in bondage to misfortune or to tyranny,
bestowed on stones and wood the name that ought not to be shared.
22 Then it was not enough for them to go wrong about knowing God,
but living in a great war of ignorance,
they label such terrible evils peace.
23 For whether they practice child-slaying rites or secret mysteries,
or hold frenzied revels with strange laws,
24 they keep neither their lives nor their marriages clean any longer;
one man ambushes and kills another,
or wounds him by corrupting his wife;
25 and all is a confusion of blood and murder, theft and deceit,
corruption, faithlessness, tumult, perjury,

26 harassing of the good, forgetfulness of favors,
defilement of souls, interchange of sex,[e]
disorder in marriages, adultery, and debauchery.
27 For worshiping idols that must not even be named[f]
is the start, source, and end of all evil.
28 For they either rave in their merriment, or prophesy lies,
or live unjustly, or readily commit perjury;
29 for since they trust in lifeless idols,
they swear wickedly and expect to suffer no harm.
30 But on both counts what is just will come after them:
that they thought badly of God, attaching themselves to idols,
and that they swore unjustly and with guile, holding holiness in contempt.
31 For it is not the power of what people swear by,
but the righteous penalty for sinners,
that always catches up with the wrongdoing of the unjust.

Notes

- a (14:6) Gen 6:1–4. The "raft" is Noah's ark.
- b (14:7) Later Christian writers applied this line to the cross; in its setting it refers to the ark.
- c (14:12) Here, as often in the prophets, a figure for unfaithfulness to God.
- d (14:21) Greek "for living."
- e (14:26) Greek geneseōs enallagē, "exchange of origin"; the sense is disputed, perhaps "perversion of nature."
- f (14:27) Or "nameless idols."

Chapter 15

1 But you, our God, are kind and truthful,
long-suffering, governing everything with mercy.
2 For even if we sin, we are yours, aware of your might;
but we will not sin, knowing that you count us as yours.
3 For to be acquainted with you is righteousness made whole,
and to recognize your might is the taproot of deathlessness.
4 We have not been led astray by what human craft has wickedly devised,

nor by the barren toil of those who paint shadow-pictures,
a shape smeared with assorted colors,
5 the sight of which comes to fools as a reproach,[a]
and one longs for the breathless form of a dead likeness.
6 Lovers of evil things and worthy of such hopes
are those who make them and those who desire them and those who worship them.
7 For a potter, pressing soft earth,
toils to mold each thing for our use;
yet out of one and the same clay he forms
the vessels meant for clean work and those for the opposite, all in the same way;
and what use each of them is to have,
the clay-worker decides.
8 And with evil labor he molds a vain god from the same clay,
he who a little while ago came into being out of earth
and in a little while goes back to that from which he was taken,
when the debt of the soul lent him is called in.
9 Yet his care is not that he must labor and die,
nor that his span of life is short;
rather he vies with goldsmiths and silversmiths
and copies the bronze-workers,
and holds it a glory to shape false things.
10 His heart is ashes, his hope cheaper than dirt,
and his life of less worth than clay,
11 for he never knew the One who molded him,
who breathed into him a soul that works
and blew into him a spirit of life.
12 He reckoned our life to be a plaything,
and existence a fair for making profit,
for one must make money, he says, from any source, even from evil.
13 For this one knows beyond all others that he is sinning,
when out of earthly stuff he makes brittle wares and graven images.

14 But most foolish of all, and more miserable than an infant's soul,
are the enemies of your people who oppressed them.[b]
15 For they counted even every idol of the nations as gods,
which have no eyes to use for seeing,
no nostrils for drawing in air,
no ears for hearing,
no fingers on their hands for touching,
and feet that are idle for walking.
16 For a human being made them,
and one whose own spirit is borrowed formed them;
for no human being can form a god like himself.
17 Being mortal, with lawless hands he works a corpse;
for he outranks what he reveres:
he once had life, but they never.
18 Moreover, they worship even the most hateful animals,
which, compared for stupidity, are worse than all others;
19 Nor do they even happen to be fair to look at, as animals go, so as to be wanted,
but they have fled both from God's praise and from his blessing.[c]

Notes

- a (15:5) Or, with a slight change, "stirs desire in fools."
- b (15:14) The Egyptians.
- c (15:19) Compare Gen 1:31; 3:14.

Chapter 16

1 So by creatures of that same sort they paid a fitting penalty,
tortured by swarms of vermin.
2 In place of that punishment you did good to your people,
and for the craving of their appetite
you made ready a novel taste, quails for food,[a]
3 so that the others, wanting food,
might turn away even from the hunger they could not help
because of the hideousness of the creatures sent upon them,[b]
while your people, after going short for a little while,
might share in a novel taste.

4 For on those tyrants a want that could not be avoided had to come,
but to these it had only to be shown how their foes were being tortured.
5 For even when the dreadful fury of beasts came upon them,
and they were perishing by the bites of twisting snakes,[c]
your anger did not stay to the end;
6 for a short time they were thrown into alarm for their correction,
having a token of rescue to bring the command of your law to mind.
7 For the one who turned was kept safe not by the thing he looked at,
but on account of you, who rescue all.
8 And in this too you persuaded our foes
that you are he who sets free from every harm.
9 For them the bites of locusts and of flies killed,
and no cure for their life was discovered,
since they deserved to be chastised by such things;
10 but your sons not even the fangs of venom-spitting serpents overcame,
for your mercy came alongside and cured them.
11 For to call your sayings to mind they were stung,
and swiftly brought through safely,
so that they might not fall into deep forgetting
and be cut off from your good deeds.
12 For it was neither herb nor plaster that made them well,
but your word, Lord, which makes all things whole.
13 For you hold authority over life and over death,
and you bring down to the gates and bring up.
14 A man may kill through his evil,
but the spirit, once gone out, he does not bring back,
nor does he free the soul that has been taken.
15 To escape from your hand is impossible;
16 For the ungodly, who denied that they knew you,
were whipped by the might of your arm,
chased by strange rains and hailstorms and downpours that would

not be begged off,
and eaten up by fire.[d]
17 For—the most amazing thing—in water, which puts out everything,
the fire burned even more strongly,
since the universe fights for the righteous.
18 For at one time the flame was tamed,
so as not to burn up the animals sent against the ungodly,
but that they themselves, on seeing it, might grasp
that God's judgment was driving them;
19 and at another time, even in the midst of water, it blazed beyond fire's own power,
to ruin the yield of an unrighteous land.
20 In place of these you fed your people the nourishment of angels,
and bread made ready you sent them from heaven without their labor,
having power for every pleasure and fitting every taste.[e]
21 For your food[f] showed your kindness toward your children,
and, suiting the appetite of whoever ate it,
it turned into whatever each one desired.
22 Snow and ice[g] held out against fire and did not melt,
that they might know that it was fire that ruined the enemies' harvests,
fire flaming in the hail
and lightning-flashing in the rains;
23 and this same fire, again, so that the righteous might be fed,
had forgotten even its own power.
24 For the creation that serves you, its maker,
is stretched tight to chastise the unrighteous,
and slackens to do good to those who rely on you.
25 So then too, being changed into everything,
it was in service to your gift that nourishes all,
according to the wish of those in want,
26 so that your sons, whom you loved, Lord, might learn
that it is not the yield of harvests that feeds a human being,
but your saying that keeps safe those who believe in you.[h]

27 For what was not ruined by fire
melted simply when it was warmed by a brief sunbeam,
28 so that people would know they must get up before sunrise to thank you,
and must address you as daylight begins;
29 For the ungrateful man's hope will thaw like winter's hoarfrost
and run off like water that serves no purpose.

Notes

- a (16:2) Num 11:31–32; Exod 16:13.
- b (16:3) The frogs and other plagues (Exod 8).
- c (16:5) Num 21:6–9.
- d (16:16) The plague of hail and lightning (Exod 9:13–35).
- e (16:20) The manna (Exod 16; Ps 78:25). Jewish tradition held that the manna tasted as each person wished.
- f (16:21) Or "sustenance"; Greek hypostasis.
- g (16:22) "Snow and ice" here describe the manna (Num 11:7; Exod 16:14, 21).
- h (16:26) Compare Deut 8:3.

Chapter 17

1 Great are your judgments and hard to recount;
therefore souls without instruction went astray.
2 For when lawless men had supposed that they held a holy nation in their power,
they lay prisoners of darkness and captives of a long night,
shut in under their roofs,
exiles from the everlasting providence.[a]
3 For thinking to go unseen in their secret sins,
they were scattered under a dark curtain of forgetfulness,
horribly dismayed and thrown into panic by apparitions.
4 For not even the inner chamber that held them kept them free of fear,
but noises crashed around them and terrified them,
and gloomy phantoms with unsmiling faces appeared.
5 No force of fire had strength to give light,
nor did the bright flames of the stars endure to lighten that hateful night.

6 Only a self-kindled blaze showed through to them, full of fear,
and, terrified at the sight they could not see,
they thought the things they did see worse still.
7 The tricks of the magic art lay humbled,
and its boast of wisdom was put to a shameful test.
8 For those who promised to drive away terrors and disorders from a sick soul
were themselves sick with a fear that deserved laughter.
9 For even when nothing alarming was there to frighten them,
they were startled out of their wits by vermin creeping past and by reptiles hissing,
10 they perished trembling,
refusing even to look at the air, which can be fled from nowhere.
11 For wickedness is a cowardly thing, condemned by its own witness;[b]
squeezed by conscience, it always magnifies its troubles.
12 For fear is nothing but the surrender of the help that comes from reasoning;
13 and the weaker the expectation within,
the greater it reckons its ignorance of the cause that brings the torment.
14 But they, all through that night that was truly powerless,
that came upon them from the recesses of powerless Hades,
sleeping the same sleep,
15 were now driven by monstrous specters,
now paralyzed by their soul's surrender;
for sudden and unexpected fear rushed upon them.
16 And so whoever had dropped down there
was held fast, shut up in a prison without iron bars.
17 For whether he was a farmer or a shepherd,
or a laborer out in the wild,
he was caught and suffered the unavoidable doom;
18 for they were all tied by a single chain of darkness.
Whether it was a whistling breeze,
a melodious song of birds in the thick branches,
or the rhythmic roar of rushing water,

19 or the harsh clatter of rocks tumbling down,
or the unseen racing of animals at play,
or the voice of wild beasts roaring in their utmost savagery,
or an echo rebounding from the mountains' hollows,
it unstrung them with terror.
20 For the whole world was lit up with brilliant light
and went about its work unhindered,
21 while over them alone a heavy night was spread,
an image of the darkness that was to receive them;
but heavier than the darkness were they to themselves.

Notes

- a (17:2) The ninth plague, darkness (Exod 10:21–23), is the subject of 17:1–18:4.
- b (17:11) The Greek of the first line is difficult; Swete's text repeats part of the second line.

Chapter 18

1 But for your holy ones there was very great light.
Those others,[a] hearing their voice but not seeing their shape,
called them blessed, because they too had not suffered;
2 and because they, though wronged before, were doing them no harm, they were thankful,
and begged their pardon for having been at odds with them.[b]
3 In place of these things you provided a pillar of flaming fire
as a guide for an unknown journey,
and a sun that would do no harm on their glorious wandering abroad.
4 For those others deserved to be robbed of light and imprisoned in darkness,
who had kept your sons shut up,
through whom the imperishable light of the law was to be given to the world.
5 After they decided to kill the babies of the holy ones,
when one child was abandoned and rescued,[c]
you removed their many children as punishment,
and drowned them all together in the mighty flood.

6 That night was made known beforehand to our fathers,[d]
so that, knowing surely the oaths in which they trusted, they might be of good courage.
7 By your people there was awaited
rescue for the righteous and ruin for the enemies;
8 for with that by which you took vengeance on our opponents,
with this you summoned us and gave us glory.
9 For the pious children of good people made sacrifice in secret,[e]
and together agreed to the divine law,
that the holy ones would equally share blessings and dangers;
and already they were chanting the praises of their ancestors.[f]
10 But the discordant cry of the enemies echoed back,
and a pitiful sound of mourning for children was carried abroad.
11 Slave and master were punished with like penalty,
and the commoner suffered the same as the king;
12 and all together, by one kind of death,
they had corpses beyond counting;
for the living were not even enough to bury them,
since in one instant their most prized offspring had been destroyed.
13 For though they had disbelieved everything because of their sorceries,
at the destruction of the firstborn they acknowledged the people to be God's son.
14 For when quiet silence held all things in its embrace,
and night in her own swiftness was at midcourse,
15 your all-powerful word leaped from heaven, from the royal throne,
a stern warrior, into the midst of the doomed land,
16 holding the sharp sword of your sincere command;
he stood and filled everything with death,
and while on earth he touched the sky.
17 Then at once apparitions in dreadful dreams troubled them,
and unexpected fears assailed them;
18 and one here, another there, flung down half dead,
made known the cause for which they were dying;

19 for the dreams that disturbed them had warned of this beforehand,
so that they might not perish without knowing why they suffered.
20 The righteous too were touched by a trial of death,
and in the wilderness a slaughter broke out among the multitude;[g]
yet the anger did not stay long.
21 For a faultless man[h] hurried to defend them,
bringing the weapon of his own service,
prayer and the atoning offering of incense;
he stood against the fury and ended the calamity,
proving that he was your servant.
22 He overcame the anger[i] not by bodily strength,
not by the working of weapons,
but by a word he brought the chastiser under,
calling to mind the oaths and covenants of the fathers.
23 For when the dead were already piled in heaps on each other,
he took his stand between and restrained the fury,
and blocked its path to the living.
24 For upon his robe reaching to the feet was the whole world,[j]
and the glories of the fathers on the carving of the stone in four rows,
and your majesty on the diadem of his head.
25 To these the destroyer yielded; these he[k] feared;
for only to taste of the wrath was enough.

Notes

- a (18:1) Greek "those," the Egyptians.
- b (18:2) The sense of the second line is uncertain; it may mean "and asked as a favor that they would depart."
- c (18:5) Moses (Exod 2:1–10). The "mighty water" is the Red Sea (Exod 14).
- d (18:6) The Passover night (Exod 11–12); compare Gen 15:13–14.
- e (18:9) The Passover sacrifice (Exod 12).
- f (18:9) Or "the fathers already leading the songs of praise."
- g (18:20) Num 16:41–50.
- h (18:21) Aaron.
- i (18:22) Greek ochlon, "the multitude," probably a slip for cholon, "the wrath," as many editors read.
- j (18:24) Exod 28. Philo and Josephus interpret the high priest's vestments as an image of the cosmos.

• k (18:25) Greek “they”; some manuscripts read “he.”

Chapter 19

1 But upon the ungodly a merciless anger pressed to the end,
for he knew beforehand even what they would do:
2 how, though they themselves had permitted your people to depart
and hurriedly sent them on their way,
they would change their minds and pursue them.
3 For with their mourning still in their hands,
and while they were wailing over the tombs of the dead,
they drew upon themselves another senseless thought,
and those whom they had entreated to leave and thrown out,
these they hunted as runaways.
4 For the necessity they had earned dragged them to this end,
and cast into them oblivion of what had befallen,
so that they might fill up beforehand the chastisement still lacking to their torments,
5 and that your people might experience an incredible journey,
while they themselves met a strange death.
6 For the whole creation was shaped again from above in its own kind,[a]
serving your particular commands,
that your servants might be guarded unharmed.
7 There was beheld the cloud that shaded the encampment,
the rising of dry land out of water that had stood there before,
out of the Red Sea a road with nothing in its way,
and a green-bearing plain out of the violent surge,
8 through which the whole nation passed, protected by your hand,
after gazing on marvelous wonders.
9 For they ranged like horses,
and leaped like lambs,
praising you, Lord, who delivered them.
10 For they still recalled what happened during their stay,
how in place of livestock the land produced gnats,
and in place of fish the river belched out a swarm of frogs.

11 Later on they saw also a new brood of birds,
when, carried away by desire, they asked for dainty dishes;
12 for, to satisfy them, quails came up from the sea.[b]
13 The punishments came upon the sinners
not without prior signs in the violence of thunder;[c]
for they suffered justly for their own wicked acts,
for they practiced a more bitter hatred of strangers.
14 Others[d] had refused to receive strangers when they arrived,
but these made slaves of guests who were their benefactors.
15 And not only so, but there will be some punishment for those others,
because they received foreigners with hostility;
16 but these, after receiving them with festal celebrations,
afflicted with dreadful labors those who had already shared the same rights.
17 And they were struck with blindness too,
as those others were at the doors of the righteous one,[ef]
when, wrapped in gaping darkness,
each went seeking the passage through his own doors.
18 For the elements, being retuned among themselves,
as on a harp the sounds alter the name of the rhythm[g]
while always keeping their tone,
as one may picture exactly from viewing what happened.
19 For things of dry land were turned into water creatures,
and swimming things went over onto the earth;[h]
20 Fire retained its strength in water,
and water forgot its fire-quenching nature.
21 Flames, by contrast, did not eat away
the bodies of the fragile creatures that moved among them,
nor did they melt the ice-like, easily dissolved heavenly food.[i]
22 For in all respects, Lord, you have made your people great and glorified them,
and you did not overlook them, standing by them at every time and place.

Notes

- a (19:6) The thought recalls a new creation; compare 19:18–21.
- b (19:12) Num 11:31.
- c (19:13) Swete's text, following Vaticanus, places the clause "for they practiced a more bitter hatred of strangers" at the end of verse 13; the numbering of verses 13–14 differs among editions.
- d (19:14) The men of Sodom (Gen 19).
- e (19:17) The ninth plague (Exod 10:21–23).
- f (19:17) Lot (Gen 19:11).
- g (19:18) The Greek text of this verse is uncertain in places; Swete marks two words as doubtful.
- h (19:19) The Israelites with their cattle passed through the sea; the frogs came up onto land.
- i (19:21) The manna; compare 16:22.

Sirach (Ben Sira)

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

Prologue of the Greek Translator

Many great things have been handed down to us through the Law and the Prophets and the other writers who came after them, and on their account Israel deserves praise for instruction and wisdom. Now it is right not only that those who read should themselves become learned, but that lovers of learning should be able, by speaking and by writing, to be of service to those outside. So my grandfather Jesus, after devoting himself more and more to reading the Law and the Prophets and the rest of the ancestral books, and after gaining a good command of them, was moved to write something of his own on matters of instruction and wisdom, so that those who love learning, once they had taken this in as well, might go much further in a life lived by the law. / You are urged, then, to read with goodwill and close attention, and to make allowance wherever, despite the care spent on the rendering, we may seem to fall short with some of the phrases. For what is said in Hebrew does not have the same force when it is carried over into another tongue. And this is true of more than this book: when the Law itself, the Prophecies, and the remaining books are read in their original language, they differ considerably. / In the thirty-eighth year of King Euergetes I came to Egypt and stayed some time, and I found a copy that gave no small instruction. I thought it most necessary to apply some zeal and labor of my own to translating this book. Through that span of time I brought much wakefulness and skill to the task of finishing the book and publishing it for those living abroad who wish to love learning and are training their ways to live by the law.

The Wisdom of Jesus son of Sirach

1 All wisdom is from the Lord,
and it is with him to the age.

2 The sand of the seas, the drops of rain,
and the days of the age — who will number them out?
3 The height of heaven, the breadth of the earth,
the depths below, and wisdom itself: who can trace them?
4 Wisdom was created before all things,
and prudent understanding is from the age.
5 [The spring of wisdom is God's word on high,
and her paths are commands everlasting.][c]
6 The root of wisdom — to whom has it been laid bare?
Her clever devices — who has come to know them?
7 [Wisdom's knowledge — to whom has it been shown?
Her rich experience — who has grasped it?]
8 There is One who is wise, exceedingly to be feared,
seated upon his throne —
9 the Lord. He himself created her;
he saw her and numbered her
and poured her out over all his works,
10 upon all flesh, as he chose to give,
and he supplied her richly to those who love him.[d]
11 The fear of the Lord is glory and a ground for boasting,
gladness and a garland of exultation.
12 The fear of the Lord will delight the heart
and will give gladness and joy and long days.[e]
13 With the one who fears the Lord it will go well at the last;
on the day of his death he will find favor.[f]
14 To fear the Lord is where wisdom begins;
with the faithful she was created in the womb.
15 Among human beings she made her nest, a foundation from the age,
and among their offspring she will be held in trust.
16 To fear the Lord is wisdom's fullness;
she makes people drunk with her fruits.
17 She will fill her whole house with things to be desired,
and her storerooms with her produce.

18 The fear of the Lord is wisdom's garland,
making peace and sound health bloom.[g]
19 He saw her and numbered her;[h]
she rained down knowledge and discerning understanding,
and raised high the glory of those who hold her fast.
20 To fear the Lord is the root of wisdom,
and length of days are her branches.
21 [The fear of the Lord drives sins away,
and where it stays, it turns aside all anger.]
22 Unrighteous rage cannot be acquitted,[i]
for the swing of his rage is his ruin.
23 Until the right time the patient will hold out,
and later gladness will spring up for him.
24 Until the right time he will hide his words,
and the lips of many will tell out his good sense.
25 In wisdom's treasure chests are the proverbs of knowledge,
but reverence for God is a horror to the sinner.
26 If you crave wisdom, keep the commandments,
and the Lord will furnish her to you.
27 Wisdom and instruction are found in the fear of the Lord,
and he delights in faithfulness and gentleness.
28 Do not be disobedient to the fear of the Lord,
and do not come to him with a doubled heart.
29 Do not act a part in people's mouths,[j]
and keep watch on your lips.
30 Do not exalt yourself, or you may fall
and bring disgrace upon your own soul.
The Lord will expose your secrets
and throw you down before the whole assembly,
because you did not approach him in the fear of the Lord,
and your heart was full of deceit.

Notes

- a (1:title) Greek Iēsous, the Greek form of Joshua (Hebrew Yeshua). In 50:27 the author is called "Jesus son of Sirach son of Eleazar of Jerusalem"; Hebrew MS B there reads "Simeon son of Jeshua son of Eleazar son of Sira," as reported.

- b (1:title) Ptolemy VIII Euergetes II, who counted his reign from 170 BC; his thirty-eighth year is 132 BC. The translator arrived then and finished the work some time later.
- c (1:5) Verse 5 is lacking in Swete's text and in the oldest Greek manuscripts; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII) and the Latin. So also verses 7 and 21 below.
- d (1:10) The Greek of the second translation adds: "Love for the Lord is glorious wisdom; he gives a share of her to those he appears to, so that they may see him."
- e (1:12) GII adds: "The fear of the Lord is a gift from the Lord, and it sets one upon paths of love."
- f (1:13) Or "he will be blessed"; the Greek manuscripts differ, as reported.
- g (1:18) GII adds: "Both are gifts of God for peace; boasting opens wide for those who love him."
- h (1:19) The first line repeats 1:9; some editors treat it as a scribal repetition.
- i (1:22) Greek "be justified."
- j (1:29) Or "before people"; the Hebrew is not extant here.

Chapter 2

1 Child, if you come forward to serve the Lord,
get your soul ready for testing.
2 Keep your heart straight and stand firm,
and do not rush about in the time of calamity.
3 Cling to him and do not draw away,
so that you may be made great at your end.
4 Whatever is brought upon you, take it,
and in the turns of your humbling be patient.
5 For in fire gold is assayed,
and those acceptable to God in the furnace of humbling.[a]
6 Trust him, and he will take your part;
make your ways straight and set your hope on him.
7 You who fear the Lord, wait for his mercy,
and do not swerve, so that you do not fall.
8 You who fear the Lord, trust him,
and your wage will not slip away.
9 You who fear the Lord, hope for good things,
for gladness of the age and for mercy.[b]
10 Look at the generations of old and see:
who ever trusted the Lord and was shamed?

Who stayed in the fear of him and was abandoned?
Who called upon him and was overlooked by him?
11 For the Lord is full of pity and mercy;
he lets sins go and saves in a time of affliction.
12 Woe to timid hearts and drooping hands,
and to the sinner who sets foot on two tracks!
13 Woe to the drooping heart, for it has no trust!
Therefore it will have no shelter.
14 Woe to you who have thrown away your endurance!
What will you do on the day the Lord makes his visit?
15 Those who fear the Lord will not defy his words,
and those who love him will keep to his ways.
16 Those who fear the Lord will look for what pleases him,
and those who love him will find their fill in the law.
17 Those who fear the Lord will make their hearts ready,
and before him they will bring their souls low.
18 Let us fall into the hands of the Lord
and not into human hands;
for as his greatness is,
so too is his mercy.[c]

Notes

- a (2:5) GII adds: "In sickness and in poverty be confident in him."
- b (2:9) GII adds: "For his reward is an everlasting gift with joy."
- c (2:18) Compare 2 Sam 24:14. Some witnesses add a line, as reported: "and as his name is, so also are his works."

Chapter 3

1 Listen to me, your father, children,
and act accordingly, so that you may be kept safe.
2 For the Lord gave the father glory over the children,
and made firm the mother's right over her sons.
3 Whoever honors a father atones for sins,
4 and whoever gives glory to his mother is like one storing up treasure.
5 Whoever honors a father will have gladness from his own children,
and on the day of his prayer he will be heard.

6 Whoever gives glory to a father will have long days,
and whoever heeds the Lord will give his mother rest;
7 he will serve his parents as a slave serves masters.[a]
8 In deed and in word honor your father,
so that blessing from him may come upon you.
9 For a father's blessing props up the houses of children,
but a mother's curse pulls up foundations.
10 Do not seek glory in your father's dishonor,
for that is no glory to you.
11 For a person's glory springs from his father's honor,
and a mother in disgrace is a reproach to her children.
12 Child, support your father in his old age,
and never grieve him while he lives;
13 even if his understanding fails, bear with him,
and do not slight him while you are in your full strength.
14 For kindness to a father will not be forgotten;
it will be built up for you as a credit against sins;
15 on the day of your affliction it will be remembered for you;
like fair weather on frost,
so your sins will dissolve.
16 Like one who reviles God is he who leaves his father in the lurch,
and one who stirs his mother to anger lies under the Lord's curse.
17 Child, carry out your tasks with mildness,
and you will be loved by those whom God accepts.[b]
18 The greater you are, the more you must make yourself low,
and you will find favor before the Lord.
19 [Many stand high and are famed,
yet to the gentle he discloses his secret things.][c]
20 For the Lord's might is great,
and by the lowly he is glorified.
21 What is too hard for you, do not seek out;
what is too strong for you, do not search into.
22 Think about what you have been commanded,
for you have no need of things hidden.

23 Do not busy yourself with matters beyond your tasks,
for more than human understanding has already been shown you.
24 For their own conjecture has misled many,
and wicked fancies have made their thinking slide.
25 With no pupils in the eyes there will be no light;
and where knowledge is lacking, make no claim to wisdom.[d]
26 A stubborn heart will come to grief at the end,
and whoever loves danger will perish in it.
27 A stubborn heart will be weighed down by troubles,
and the sinner piles sin upon sin.
28 For the misfortune of the proud there is no cure,
since a plant of wickedness has taken root in him.
29 The mind of the prudent will ponder a parable,
and an attentive ear is what the wise desire.
30 Water puts out a blazing fire,
and almsgiving atones for sins.
31 Whoever repays favors keeps the future in mind,
and when he begins to fall he will find something to lean on.

Notes

- a (3:7) GII prefixes: "Whoever fears the Lord will honor his father."
- b (3:17) Greek "by an acceptable person"; the Hebrew (MS A, as reported) has "more than one who gives gifts."
- c (3:19) Verse 19 is lacking in Swete's text; it belongs to GII.
- d (3:25) Verse 25 is lacking in Swete's text and in the main Greek manuscripts; it is found in other witnesses and in the Hebrew (MS A), as reported.

Chapter 4

1 Child, do not cheat the poor man of his living,
and do not keep needy eyes waiting.
2 Do not pain a hungry soul,
and do not exasperate a man in his want.
3 Do not add turmoil to a heart already provoked,
and do not put off a gift to one in need.
4 Do not spurn a suppliant in distress,
and do not turn your face from a poor man.

5 Do not turn your eye from one who begs,
and give no one occasion to curse you;
6 for if he curses you in the bitterness of his soul,
his Maker will listen to his plea.
7 Make yourself dear to the assembly,
and bow your head to a great man.
8 Bend your ear to a poor man,
and answer him with peaceable words, mildly.
9 Rescue the wronged from the hand of the wrongdoer,
and do not lose heart when you sit in judgment.
10 Be like a father to orphans,
and like a husband to their mother;
then you will be like a son of the Most High,
and he will love you more than your own mother does.
11 Wisdom raises her sons on high
and takes hold of those who seek her.
12 Whoever loves her loves life,
and those who rise at dawn to meet her will be filled with gladness.
13 Whoever holds her fast will inherit glory,
and wherever she enters, the Lord gives blessing.
14 Those who wait on her minister to the Holy One,
and those who love her the Lord loves.
15 Whoever obeys her will judge nations,
and whoever attends to her will dwell in confidence.[a]
16 If he trusts her, he will inherit her,
and his descendants will hold her as a possession.
17 For at first she walks with him by twisting ways;
she brings fear and cowardice upon him
and torments him with her discipline
until she can trust his soul,
and she tests him with her ordinances.
18 Then she comes straight back to him again and gladdens him
and lays bare her secrets to him.

19 If he goes astray, she will abandon him
and hand him over to his own downfall.
20 Watch for the right time and guard yourself from evil,
and do not be ashamed where your own soul is concerned.
21 There is a shame that brings sin,
and there is a shame that brings glory and grace.
22 Do not show favor to others against your own soul,
and do not let deference be your downfall.
23 Do not hold back a word when it can bring rescue.[b]
24 For by speech wisdom is made known,
and instruction by the utterance of the tongue.
25 Do not argue against the truth,
but be abashed at your own want of learning.
26 Feel no shame in owning up to your sins,
and do not push against the stream of a river.
27 Do not lay yourself down as a doormat for a fool,[c]
and do not show favor to a ruler.
28 Contend for the truth until death,
and the Lord God will fight on your side.
29 Do not be rough with your tongue,
or sluggish and slack in your works.
30 Do not be a lion in your own house,
or full of suspicious fancies among your servants.
31 Do not let your hand be held open to take
and clenched shut when it is time to pay back.

Notes

- a (4:15) The Hebrew (MS A), as reported, has "will judge truly" (one letter different from "nations") and "will dwell in my inner rooms"; from verse 15 to 19 the Hebrew speaks in the first person as Wisdom.
- b (4:23) GII adds: "and do not hide your wisdom for the sake of looking well."
- c (4:27) Greek "do not spread yourself beneath."

Chapter 5

1 Do not lean on your money,
and do not say, "I am self-sufficient."

2 Do not follow your own soul and your strength
so as to walk in the cravings of your heart.
3 And do not say, “Who will lord it over me?”
for the Lord will surely exact punishment.
4 Do not say, “I sinned, and what happened to me?”
for the Lord is slow to anger.
5 Do not be so free of fear about atonement
that you add sin to sins.
6 And do not say, “His compassion is great;
he will atone for the mass of my sins”;
for mercy and wrath are both with him,
and his rage settles upon sinners.
7 Do not wait to turn back to the Lord,
and do not keep putting it off from day to day;
for suddenly the Lord’s wrath will burst out,
and in the time of punishment you will be wiped out.
8 Do not lean on unjust money,
for it will be no use to you on the day of disaster.
9 Do not winnow in every wind,
and do not walk down every path;
that is what the double-tongued sinner does.
10 Stand fixed in what you understand,
and let your word be one.
11 Be quick to listen,
and give your answer with patience.
12 If you have understanding, answer your neighbor;
if not, put your hand on your mouth.
13 Glory and disgrace come by talking,
and a person’s tongue can be his fall.
14 Do not get called a whisperer,
and do not set ambushes with your tongue;
for shame falls on the thief,
and harsh condemnation on the double-tongued.
15 In great and small alike do not act in ignorance.

Chapter 6

1 Do not turn from friend into enemy;
a bad name inherits shame and reproach,
as does the sinner with a double tongue.
2 Do not lift yourself up in your soul's own counsel,
or your soul will be torn in pieces as by a bull;[a]
3 you will eat up your leaves and lose your fruit
and leave yourself like a dried-out tree.
4 A wicked soul ruins the one who owns it
and makes him a thing for his enemies to gloat over.
5 A sweet throat multiplies its friends,
and a gracious tongue multiplies friendly greetings.
6 Let those at peace with you be many,
but let your counselor be one in a thousand.
7 If you gain a friend, gain him by putting him to the test,
and do not be quick to trust him.
8 For there is a friend who is a friend when it suits him,
but will not stay by you on the day of your distress.
9 Another friend turns into an enemy
and will expose the quarrel, to your disgrace.
10 And there is a friend who shares your table
but will not stay by you on the day of your distress.
11 In your good times he will be like a second self
and speak freely to your servants;
12 if you are brought low, he will turn against you
and hide himself from your sight.
13 Keep yourself apart from your enemies,
and be on your guard with your friends.
14 A trustworthy friend is a stout covering;
the man who has found one has found treasure.
15 Nothing can be traded for a faithful friend,
and no scale can weigh his worth.
16 A faithful friend is a medicine that gives life,
and those who fear the Lord will find one.

17 Whoever fears the Lord keeps his friendship straight,
for as he is, so too is his neighbor.
18 Child, from your youth choose instruction,
and on into gray hairs you will keep finding wisdom.
19 Approach her as a farmer does, plowing and sowing,
and wait for the good harvest she brings.
You will work only a little in tilling her,
and before long you will eat what she yields.
20 How very rough she is to the untaught!
The witless will not stay with her.
21 Like a weighty stone for testing strength she will rest on him,
and he will lose no time in flinging her away.
22 For wisdom is as her name is,
and she is not plain to many.[b]
23 Listen, child, and accept my judgment,
and do not refuse my counsel.
24 Put your feet into her fetters
and your neck into her collar.
25 Set your shoulder under her and carry her,
and do not chafe at her bonds.
26 Come to her with all your soul,
and keep her ways with all your might.
27 Track her out and search, and she will become known to you;
and once you have hold of her, do not let her go.
28 For in the end you will discover her repose,
and she will turn for you into joy.
29 Her fetters will become a strong shelter for you,
and her collar a robe of glory.
30 For there is a golden ornament upon her,
and her bonds are a thread of violet.[c]
31 You will put her on like a robe of glory
and set her on yourself like a crown of exultation.
32 If you are willing, child, you will be trained,
and if you give your soul to it, you will be shrewd.

33 If you love to listen, you will take in,
and if you bend your ear, you will be wise.
34 Stand among the company of the elders;
who is wise? Fasten yourself to him.
35 Be eager to hear every godly discourse,
and do not let proverbs of understanding slip away from you.
36 If you see a man of understanding, get up early to go to him,
and let your foot wear down his doorsteps.
37 Ponder the ordinances of the Lord,
and meditate on his commandments at all times.
He himself will make your heart firm,
and the wisdom you long for will be given to you.

Notes

- a (6:2) The Greek is obscure; the Hebrew (MS A) differs, as reported.
- b (6:22) Probably a play on Hebrew musar, "discipline," which can also mean "withdrawn" or "held back."
- c (6:30) Greek hyakinthinos, the blue-violet dye of the tassels in Num 15:38.

Chapter 7

1 Do no evil, and evil will never lay hold of you.
2 Stand off from what is unjust, and it will swerve away from you.
3 Child, do not sow the furrows of injustice,
or you will reap sevenfold from them.
4 Do not ask the Lord for high command,
or the king for a seat of honor.
5 Do not justify yourself before the Lord,
and do not play the sage in the king's presence.
6 Do not seek to become a judge,
or you may not be strong enough to root out injustice;
you may be overawed in the presence of a powerful man
and lay a stumbling block in the path of your uprightness.
7 Do not sin against the populace of the city,
and do not throw yourself down in the crowd.
8 Do not tie on a sin twice over,
for not even for one will you go unpunished.

9 Do not say, “He will regard the abundance of my gifts,
and when I bring them to God Most High, he will take them.”
10 Do not lose heart in your prayer,
and do not neglect to give alms.
11 Do not laugh at a person in bitterness of soul,
for there is One who brings low and lifts up.
12 Do not plow up a lie against your brother,
or do the like to a friend.
13 Refuse to tell any lie at all,
for the habit of it leads to no good.
14 Do not prattle in the company of elders,
and do not repeat yourself in your prayer.
15 Do not hate laborious work,
or farming, which was created by the Most High.
16 Do not reckon yourself in the throng of sinners;
bear in mind that wrath does not linger.
17 Humble yourself deeply,
for fire and worms are the punishment of the ungodly.[a]
18 Do not trade a friend for something of no account,
or a true brother for the gold of Ophir.[b]
19 Do not pass over a wise and good wife,
for her grace is worth more than gold.
20 Do not ill-treat a servant who works in good faith,
or a hired man who gives himself to the work.
21 Let your soul love a good servant;
do not deprive him of his freedom.[c]
22 Do you have cattle? Look after them;
and if they are useful to you, keep them.
23 Do you have children? Train them,
and bend their necks from their youth.
24 Do you have daughters? Take care of their bodies,
and do not let your face shine on them too brightly.
25 Marry off your daughter, and a great task is done;
but give her to a sensible man.

26 Is there a wife to your liking? Do not send her away;
but to a wife you loathe do not entrust yourself.[d]
27 Honor your father with all your heart,
and do not forget the labor pains of your mother.
28 Remember that through them you came into being;
and what can you repay them for what they gave you?
29 With all your soul hold the Lord in awe,
and hold his priests in high regard.
30 With all your strength love the One who made you,
and do not abandon his ministers.
31 Fear the Lord and honor the priest,
and give him the portion that was commanded for him:
the firstfruits, the guilt offering, the gift of the shoulders,
the sacrifice of consecration, and the firstfruits of the holy things.[e]
32 Stretch out your hand to the poor as well,
so that your blessing may be made complete.
33 A gift brings grace before everyone who lives;
do not withhold kindness even from the dead.
34 Do not keep away from those who weep,
but mourn with those who mourn.
35 Do not be slow to visit the sick,
for by such deeds you will be loved.
36 In all you say, remember your last end,
and you will never sin.

Notes

- a (7:17) The Hebrew (MS A), as reported, reads "for what awaits mortals is worms"; the Greek introduces the idea of punishment by fire (compare Isa 66:24).
- b (7:18) Greek Soupheir, the gold-land of Ophir.
- c (7:21) Compare Exod 21:2; Deut 15:12–18.
- d (7:26) The second line is lacking in Swete's text; it is found in other witnesses and in the Hebrew (MS A), as reported.
- e (7:31) Compare Lev 7:28–36; Num 18:8–20; Deut 18:3–4.

Chapter 8

1 Do not fight it out with a powerful man,
or you may fall into his hands.

2 Do not quarrel with a rich man,
or he may set his weight against you;
for gold has ruined many
and has bent the hearts of kings.
3 Do not fight it out with a loud-mouthed man,
and do not pile wood on his fire.
4 Do not make sport with an ill-bred man,
or your forebears may be insulted.
5 Do not reproach a person who is turning from sin;
remember that we all are liable to penalty.
6 Do not dishonor a person in his old age,
for some of us also are growing old.
7 Do not gloat over the dead;
remember that we all come to our end.
8 Do not disregard the discourse of the wise,
but occupy yourself with their proverbs;
for from them you will learn instruction
and how to serve the great.
9 Do not miss the talk of the aged,
for they too learned from their fathers;
from them you will learn understanding
and how to give an answer when it is needed.
10 Do not kindle a sinner's coals,
or you may be scorched in the flame of his fire.
11 Do not jump up and leave before an insolent man,
or he will sit like an ambush at your mouth.
12 Do not lend to a man stronger than you;
and if you lend, count it as lost.
13 Do not stand surety beyond your means;
and if you do, give thought to paying.
14 Do not go to law against a judge,
for they will decide for him as his rank requires.
15 Do not take to the road beside a daredevil,
or he will be heavy on you;

he will act on his own whim,
and his folly will drag you down to ruin with him.
16 Do not pick a fight with a hot-tempered man,
and do not cross the wilderness in his company;
for blood counts as nothing in his eyes,
and where there is no help he will strike you down.
17 Do not take counsel with a fool,
for he cannot keep a matter to himself.
18 Do nothing secret in front of a stranger,
for you do not know what it will bring forth.
19 Do not lay your heart open to everyone,
and do not let anyone count it a favor to you.[a]

Notes

- a (8:19) Or, by another reading, "and do not drive away your good fortune"; the Greek is uncertain.

Chapter 9

1 Do not be jealous over the wife you hold close,
and do not school her in evil to your own hurt.
2 Do not give your soul to a woman
so that she sets her foot upon your strength.
3 Do not go to meet a loose woman,
or you may fall into her snares.
4 Do not linger with a woman who sings to the harp,
or you may be caught by her tricks.
5 Do not fix your gaze on a maiden,
or you may be tripped up and pay fines because of her.[a]
6 Do not give your soul to prostitutes,
or you may lose your inheritance.
7 Do not peer about in the lanes of the city,
and do not wander in its deserted corners.
8 Turn your eye away from a shapely woman,
and do not stare at beauty that belongs to another;
by a woman's beauty many have been led astray,
and from it desire is kindled like fire.

9 Never sit at table with a married woman,
and do not carouse with her over wine,
or your soul may lean toward her,
and in your passion you may slide into ruin.[b]
10 Do not desert an old friend,
for a new one does not match him.
A new friend is new wine;
when it has grown old, you will drink it with gladness.
11 Do not envy a sinner's glory,
for you do not know how he will be overthrown.
12 Do not delight in what delights the ungodly;
remember that they will not go unpunished before they reach Hades.
13 Stay away from a man who has the power to kill,
and the fear of death will not haunt you.
If you do go near him, do not make a false move,
or he may take your life.
Know that you are walking among traps
and strolling along a city's battlements.
14 As far as you can, size up your neighbors,
and consult with the wise.
15 Let your discussion be with people of understanding,
and let all your talk be about the law of the Most High.
16 Let righteous men be your companions at table,
and let your boasting be in the fear of the Lord.
17 A work wins praise for the craftsman's hand,
and a ruler of the people for the wisdom of his speech.
18 A man of loose tongue is dreaded in his city,
and one who is rash in his talk will be hated.

Notes

- a (9:5) Compare Exod 22:16–17; Deut 22:28–29.
- b (9:9) Greek "with your spirit"; the Hebrew (MS A), as reported, has "in blood," that is, to a death sentence (compare Lev 20:10).

Chapter 10

1 A wise judge will school his people,
and the rule of a man of understanding will be well ordered.
2 As the people's judge is, so are his officers,
and as the city's ruler is, so are all who dwell in it.
3 An unschooled king will ruin his people,
but a city is settled through the good sense of those in power.
4 Authority over the earth lies in the Lord's hand,
and at the right season he will raise up over it the one who is fit.
5 A man's success lies in the Lord's hand,
and on the person of the scribe he will lay his own glory.[a]
6 Do not nurse rage at your neighbor for every wrong,
and do nothing by deeds of insolence.
7 Arrogance is hateful before the Lord and before people,
and injustice gives offense to both.
8 Kingship is shifted from nation to nation
because of injustice and insolence and money.[b]
9 Why is earth and ashes proud?
Even while alive, its innards are cast away.[c]
10 A long illness — the physician scoffs at it;
a king today, and tomorrow he will be dead.
11 For when a person dies,
creeping things and wild beasts and worms are what he inherits.
12 The start of human pride is standing off from the Lord:
the heart has withdrawn from its Maker.
13 For the start of pride is sin,
and whoever clings to it showers forth abomination.
On this account the Lord brought on them strange calamities
and overturned them utterly.
14 The Lord has pulled down the thrones of rulers
and seated the gentle in their stead.
15 The Lord has plucked up the roots of nations
and planted the lowly in their stead.

16 The Lord has overturned the lands of nations
and destroyed them down to the foundations of the earth.
17 Some of them he has dried up and destroyed,
and he has made their remembrance cease from the earth.
18 Arrogance was not created for human beings,
nor savage anger for those born of women.
19 What seed is held in honor? Human seed.
What seed is held in honor? Those who fear the Lord.
What seed is held in dishonor? Human seed.
What seed is held in dishonor? Those who step over commandments.
20 Among brothers their leader is held in honor,
and those who fear the Lord are so in his eyes.
21 [The fear of the Lord is where acceptance begins,
but hardness and arrogance are where rejection begins.][d]
22 Rich man, man of note, and poor man alike —
their boast is the fear of the Lord.
23 It is not just to dishonor a poor man who has understanding,
and it is not proper to give glory to a sinful man.
24 Magnate, judge, and ruler will receive honor,
yet not one of them stands above the man who fears the Lord.
25 Free men will wait upon a wise servant,
and a man of knowledge will not grumble at it.
26 Do not play the sage over doing your work,
and do not give yourself airs in the time of your want.
27 Better the man who works and has plenty of all things
than the one who struts about with airs and lacks bread.
28 Child, give your soul glory in meekness,
and give it honor according to its worth.
29 Who will declare righteous one who sins against his own soul?
And who will give glory to one who dishonors his own life?
30 A poor man is given glory for his knowledge,
and a rich man is given glory for his riches.

31 One given glory in poverty — how much more in riches!
And one held in dishonor in riches — how much more in poverty!

Notes

- a (10:5) Greek grammateus, "scribe"; the Hebrew (MS A), as reported, has "ruler" or "lawgiver" (mehoqeq).
- b (10:8) GII adds: "Nothing is more lawless than one who loves money, for such a one puts his own soul up for sale."
- c (10:9) The Greek is difficult (literally "I cast away"); the sense is that the body is decaying even in life.
- d (10:21) Verse 21 is lacking in Swete's text; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII).

Chapter 11

1 The wisdom of a lowly man will lift up his head
and seat him in the midst of great men.
2 Do not praise a man for his good looks,
and do not loathe a person for how he appears.
3 Small among winged things is the bee,
but its fruit is first among sweet things.
4 Do not boast of the wrapping of your garments,
and do not exalt yourself on a day of glory;
for the works of the Lord are wonders,
and his works are hidden from human beings.
5 Many tyrants have sat down upon the ground,
and one no one suspected has worn the diadem.
6 Many potentates have been deeply disgraced,
and men of note have been handed into others' hands.
7 Before you examine, find no fault;
understand first, and then rebuke.
8 Before you hear, do not answer,
and do not throw in words in the middle of another's speech.
9 Do not wrangle over a matter that is no need of yours,
and do not sit in session when sinners give judgment.
10 Child, do not let your dealings be about many things;
if you multiply them, you will not go clear;

if you chase, you will not catch up,
and if you run off, you will not escape.
11 There is one who labors and toils and hurries,
and he falls all the further behind.
12 There is one who is sluggish and in want of help,
short of strength and rich in poverty;
and the eyes of the Lord have looked on him for good,
and he has set him upright out of his low estate
13 and lifted up his head,
and many have been astonished at him.
14 Good things and bad, life and death,
poverty and riches — they come from the Lord.
15 [From the Lord come wisdom, discernment, and knowing the law;
from him come love and the paths of good deeds.][a]
16 [Wandering and darkness were formed along with sinners,
and for those who glory in wickedness, evil ages with them.]
17 The Lord's gift abides with the godly,
and his good pleasure will prosper them to the age.
18 There is one who grows rich by vigilance and pinching,
and this is the share of his wage:
19 when he says, "I have found rest,
and now I will eat from my goods,"
he does not know what time will go by
before he leaves them to others and dies.
20 Stand fast in your covenant and be occupied with it,
and grow old in your work.
21 Do not wonder at the works of a sinner;
trust in the Lord and keep at your labor;
for it is a light thing in the Lord's eyes
swiftly, in a moment, to make a poor man rich.
22 The blessing of the Lord is in the wage of the godly,
and in a swift hour he makes his blessing burst into bloom.
23 Do not say, "What need have I,
and what good things will be mine from now on?"

24 Do not say, "I am self-sufficient,
and what evil can be mine from now on?"
25 On a day of good things, bad things slip from memory,
and on a day of bad things, good things are not recalled.
26 For it is a light thing for the Lord on the day of one's end
to pay a person back according to his ways.
27 An hour of hardship makes delight forgotten,
and at a person's end his deeds are uncovered.
28 Count no one blessed before his end;
by his children a man will be known.
29 Do not bring every man into your house,
for the snares of the treacherous are many.
30 A decoy partridge in a basket — such is the heart of the proud,
and like a spy he watches for your fall;
31 for he lies in ambush, turning good things to evil,
and on things worth choosing he will fix a blemish.
32 From one spark of fire a whole hearth of coals grows,
and a sinful man lies in ambush for blood.
33 Beware of a wrongdoer, for he devises wickedness,
or he may give you a blemish to the age.
34 Lodge a stranger in your house, and he will twist you round with troubles
and make you a stranger to your own.

Notes

- a (11:15) Verses 15 and 16 are lacking in Swete's text; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII).

Chapter 12

1 If you do good, know whom you are doing it for,
and there will be thanks for your good deeds.
2 Do good to a godly man, and you will find repayment,
if not from him, then from the Most High.
3 No good things come to one who persists in evil,
or to one who gives no alms.

4 Give to the godly man,
and do not take the sinner's part.
5 Do good to the lowly,
and do not give to the ungodly;
hold back his loaves and do not give them to him,
so that he does not gain the upper hand over you by them;
for you will meet double evil
for all the good you do him.
6 For the Most High himself hates sinners
and will pay out vengeance on the ungodly.
7 Give to the good man,
and do not take the sinner's part.
8 A friend is not made known[a] in good times,
and an enemy is not hidden in bad times.
9 In a man's good times his enemies are in sorrow,
and in his bad times even his friend goes off from him.
10 Never trust your enemy,
for as bronze corrodes, so does his wickedness.
11 Even if he humbles himself and walks about stooped,
set your soul on watch and guard yourself from him,
and be to him like one who has wiped a mirror clean,
and you will know that it has not rusted through to the end.[b]
12 Do not stand him next to you,
or he may overturn you and take your place;
do not seat him at your right hand,
or he may go after your seat,
and at the last you will recognize my words
and be pierced by what I have said.
13 Who has pity on a charmer bitten by his serpent,
or on anyone who comes close to wild animals?
14 So too with one who goes about with a sinful man
and is mixed up in his sins.
15 He will stay with you an hour,
but if you lean aside, he will not hold out.

16 With his lips the enemy will speak sweetly,
but in his heart he will plot to tip you into a pit;
with his eyes the enemy will shed tears,
but if he finds his moment, he will not be sated with blood.
17 If evils meet you, you will find him there before you,
and as though helping, he will clip your heel.
18 He will wag his head and clap his hands
and whisper much and change his countenance.

Notes

- a (12:8) Greek "will not be punished"; probably a scribal slip for "will not be known," which the Hebrew supports, as reported.
- b (12:11) Ancient mirrors were polished bronze, which tarnished and had to be wiped.

Chapter 13

1 Whoever touches pitch will be smeared,
and whoever goes about with an arrogant man will become like him.
2 Do not lift a load too heavy for you,
and do not go about with one stronger and richer than you.
What partnership can the clay pot have with the kettle?
This one will knock against it, and that one will be smashed.
3 A rich man does wrong, and he even snorts with anger;
a poor man is wronged, and he must also plead.
4 If you are of use, he will work you;
and if you fall short, he will abandon you.
5 If you have means, he will live with you
and empty you out, and it will cost him no pain.
6 Has he need of you? He will lead you astray
and smile at you and give you hope;
he will speak fair words to you and say, "What is your need?"
7 He will shame you with his dainties
until he has emptied you out two or three times,
and at the last he will make sport of you.

After this he will see you and abandon you
and wag his head at you.
8 Take care not to be led astray
and humbled in your merriment.[a]
9 When a potentate calls you in, keep your distance,
and he will call you in all the more.
10 Do not crowd in, or you may be thrust away;
and do not stand far off, or you may be forgotten.
11 Do not venture to talk with him as an equal,
and do not believe his abundant words;
for by much talk he will test you,
and while smiling he will scrutinize you.
12 Pitiless is the one who does not keep words to himself;
he will not spare you harm and chains.
13 Keep watch and take great heed,
for you are walking side by side with your own fall.
14 [When you hear this while asleep, rouse yourself;
love the Lord every day you live,
and call to him to save you.][b]
15 Every living creature loves its like,
and every person loves his neighbor.
16 All flesh flocks together by kind,
and a man will cleave to the one who is like him.
17 What partnership can a wolf have with a lamb?
So it is with a sinner toward a godly man.
18 What peace has a hyena with a dog?
And what peace has a rich man with a poor one?
19 Wild asses in the desert are the quarry of lions;
just so, the poor are the grazing ground of the rich.
20 Lowliness is an abomination to the proud;
just so, a poor man is an abomination to the rich.
21 When a rich man totters, he is propped up by friends,
but when a lowly man falls, he is shoved away by friends too.

22 When a rich man trips, there are many to take his part;
he utters unspeakable things, and they declare him right.
A lowly man trips, and they rebuke him on top of it;
he gives voice to good sense, and no room is given him.
23 A rich man speaks, and all go quiet,
and they lift his word up to the clouds.
A poor man speaks, and they say, "Who is this?"
and if he stumbles, they help to knock him down.
24 Riches are good where there is no sin,
and poverty is evil, in the mouth of the ungodly.
25 A person's heart alters his face,
whether for good or for evil.
26 The trace of a heart in good things is a cheerful face,
but the finding out of proverbs is reasoning with toil.

Notes

- a (13:8) The Hebrew (MS A), as reported, has "in your folly."
- b (13:14) Verse 14 is lacking in Swete's text; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII).

Chapter 14

1 Blessed is the man who has not slipped with his mouth
and has not been pierced with grief for sin.
2 Blessed is the one whose soul has not condemned him
and who has not fallen from his hope.
3 Riches are not fitting for a stingy man,
and to a begrudging person, what good is money?
4 One who gathers by stinting his own soul gathers for others,
and on his good things others will live in luxury.
5 One who is mean to himself — to whom will he be good?
He will take no joy in his own money.
6 No one is meaner than the man who begrudges himself,
and this is the repayment of his wickedness.
7 Even if he does good, he does it by forgetfulness,
and at the last he lays bare his wickedness.

8 Evil is the one who begrudges with his eye,
turning away his face and overlooking souls.
9 The eye of the greedy is not filled by his share,
and wicked injustice dries up the soul.
10 An evil eye is grudging over bread,
and at his own table it is lacking.
11 Child, as far as you have the means, treat yourself well,
and bring offerings to the Lord worthily.
12 Remember that death will not delay,
and the covenant of Hades has not been shown to you.
13 Before you come to your end, do good to a friend,
and as far as your strength allows, reach out and give to him.
14 Do not cheat yourself of a good day,
and do not let a share of good desire slip past you.
15 Will you not leave your labors to another,
and your toils for dividing by lot?
16 Give and take, and treat your soul kindly,
for in Hades there is no seeking of delight.
17 All flesh grows old like a garment,
for the covenant from the age is, "You shall surely die."
18 Like leaves flourishing on a thick tree,
some it drops and others it puts forth:
so is the generation of flesh and blood,
one comes to its end and another is born.
19 Every work decays and gives out,
and the one who works at it will go away along with it.
20 Blessed is the man who will meditate on wisdom
and who will reason with his understanding,
21 who ponders her ways in his heart
and will gain insight into her secrets.
22 Go out after her like a tracker,
and lie in wait at her entryways.
23 He peeps in through her windows
and will listen at her doorways;

24 he lodges close beside her house
and will drive a peg into her walls;
25 he will pitch his tent at her side
and will lodge in a lodging of good things;
26 he will set his children in her shelter
and will camp beneath her branches;
27 Under her he will find cover from the burning heat,
and in her splendor he will lodge.

Chapter 15

1 The one who fears the Lord will do this,
and the one who holds fast to the law will lay hold of her.
2 Like a mother she will come out to meet him,
and as a bride taken in her youth she will receive him.
3 She will feed him the bread of understanding
and give him the water of wisdom to drink.
4 He will lean on her and not be bent,
and he will hold to her and not be put to shame.
5 She will lift him up above his neighbors
and open his mouth in the midst of the assembly.
6 Gladness and a crown of exultation
and an everlasting name will be his inheritance.
7 Senseless people will never lay hold of her,
and sinful men will never see her.
8 She is far from arrogance,
and lying men will never call her to mind.
9 Praise is not seemly in a sinner's mouth,
for it was not sent from the Lord.
10 For praise will be spoken in wisdom,
and the Lord will prosper it.
11 Do not say, "It was through the Lord that I fell away,"
for what he hates, you are not to do.
12 Do not say, "He is the one who led me astray,"
for he has no need of a sinful man.

13 Every abomination the Lord has hated,
and it is not dear to those who fear him.
14 He himself made humankind from the beginning
and left them in the hand of their own counsel.[a]
15 If you choose, you will keep the commandments,
and acting in good faith is a matter of your own choosing.
16 He has laid before you fire and water;
stretch out your hand to whichever you choose.
17 Before human beings lie life and death,
and whichever one pleases him will be given to him.
18 For great is the wisdom of the Lord;
he is strong in dominion and beholds all things;
19 and his eyes are upon those who fear him,
and he himself will take note of every human deed.
20 He has commanded no one to be ungodly,
and he has given no one leave to sin.

Notes

- a (15:14) Greek diaboulion, "deliberation"; the Hebrew, as reported, has yetser, "inclination," the word from which later Jewish teaching on the good and evil inclinations developed.

Chapter 16

1 Do not long for a crowd of useless children,
and do not take delight in ungodly sons.
2 If they multiply, do not delight in them,
unless the fear of the Lord is with them.
3 Do not put your trust in their life,
and do not rely on their place;[a]
for one is better than a thousand,
and to die childless than to have ungodly children.
4 For through one man of understanding a city will be peopled,
but a tribe of the lawless will be laid waste.
5 Many such things my eyes have seen,
and my ear has heard things mightier than these.

6 Fire will be kindled in a gathering of sinners,
and wrath has flared up against a disobedient nation.
7 He did not make atonement for the giants of old,[b]
who revolted in their strength.
8 He did not spare those among whom Lot sojourned,
whom he abhorred for their arrogance.
9 He did not pity the nation marked for destruction,[c]
those driven out in their sins;
10 so too with the six hundred thousand foot soldiers
who banded together in their hardness of heart.[d]
11 Even if there is one stiff-necked man,
it would be a wonder if he goes unpunished;
for mercy and wrath are both with him;
he is a potentate in forgiving and in pouring out wrath.
12 As great as his mercy, so great also is his reproof;
he will judge a man according to his works.
13 The sinner will not escape with his plunder,
and the endurance of the godly will not be cut short.
14 He will make room for every act of mercy;
each will find according to his works.
15 [The Lord made Pharaoh hard, so that he would not acknowledge him,
that his deeds might be known throughout the world below heaven.][e]
16 [His mercy is plain to all his creation,
and he apportioned his light and his darkness to Adam.]
17 Do not say, "I will hide from the Lord;
who will remember me from on high?
I will not be remembered among so great a people;
what am I, a soul, in the whole vast creation?"
18 Look: heaven and the heaven of heaven,
the abyss and the earth, will shake when he visits.
19 The mountains along with the foundations of the earth,
when he looks on them, are shaken with trembling.

20 Yet no heart will give thought to these things,
and who will ponder his ways?
21 As a squall that no person will see,
so the greater part of his works are hidden.
22 Works of justice — who will announce them?
Or who will wait for them? For the covenant is far off."
23 Lacking in heart is the one who ponders these things,
and a senseless man who has gone astray ponders folly.
24 Listen to me, child, and learn knowledge,
and set your heart on my words.
25 I will reveal instruction by weight
and announce knowledge with exactness.
26 When the Lord judged his works from the beginning,
and from their making he marked out their portions,
27 he set his works in array to the age,
and their first principles for their generations;
they neither hunger nor grow weary,
and they do not give out from their works.
28 Not one of them jostles its neighbor,
and to the age they will not disobey his word.
29 And after this the Lord looked down on the earth
and filled it with his good things.
30 With every kind of living soul he covered its face,
and to it they return.

Notes

- a (16:3) Greek "their place," perhaps meaning their standing or number; GII and the Hebrew add lines here, as reported.
- b (16:7) Gen 6:1–4.
- c (16:9) The Canaanites (compare Deut 7:1–2; 20:16–18).
- d (16:10) Israel in the wilderness (Num 11:21; 14:22–35).
- e (16:15) Verses 15 and 16 are lacking in Swete's text; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII). Compare Exod 7–11.

Chapter 17

1 The Lord formed a human being from the earth
and sent him back into it again.

2 Days by number and a set span he gave them,
and he gave them authority over the things on it.
3 He clothed them with strength befitting himself[a]
and made them after his own image.
4 He laid the dread of them on all flesh,
to be lords over beasts and birds.
5 [They were given the use of the five powers of the Lord;
for a sixth he granted them a share of mind,
and for a seventh, speech, the interpreter of his powers.][b]
6 Deliberation and tongue and eyes,
ears and a heart to think with, he gave them.
7 With knowing and discerning he filled them,
and he pointed out to them good and evil.
8 He set his eye on their hearts
to show them the greatness of his works,[c]
9 so that they would recount the greatness of his works,[d]
10 and they will praise the name of his holiness.
11 He set knowledge before them
and gave them the law of life as their allotment.
12 An everlasting covenant he established with them
and pointed out his judgments to them.
13 Their eyes saw the greatness of his glory,
and their ear heard the glory of his voice.
14 He said to them, "Keep away from everything unjust,"
and he gave each of them commands about his neighbor.
15 Their ways are before him at all times;
they will not be hidden from his eyes.
16 [Their ways from youth lean toward evil,
and they cannot make themselves hearts of flesh in place of stone.]
17 He appointed a ruler over every nation,
but Israel is the Lord's own portion.[e]
18 [Israel, his firstborn, he rears with discipline,
and sharing with him the light of his love, he does not neglect him.]

19 All their works are as plain to him as the sun,
and his eyes are always on their ways.
20 Their injustices are not hidden from him,
and all their sins are before the Lord.
21 [But the Lord, being good and knowing what they are made of,
has not left or forsaken them, but has spared them.]
22 A man's almsgiving is like a signet with him,
and a person's kindness he will keep like the pupil of the eye.
23 Afterward he will rise up and repay them
and render their due on their own heads.
24 Yet for those who repent he has granted a way back,
and he comforts those whose endurance is giving out.
25 Turn back to the Lord and leave off sins;
beg before his face and make the stumbling less.
26 Return to the Most High and turn away from injustice,
and hate abomination with all your might.
27 In Hades, who will praise the Most High
in the place of the living who give him thanks?
28 From a dead man, as from one who is not, thanksgiving perishes;
the living and healthy will praise the Lord.
29 How great the mercy of the Lord,
and his atonement for those who turn to him!
30 For not all things can be in human beings,
since a son of man is not deathless.
31 What is brighter than the sun? Yet even it fails.
And flesh and blood will ponder evil.
32 He inspects the host of the height of heaven,
but human beings are all earth and ashes.

Notes

- a (17:3) Greek "according to themselves"; the Latin and Syriac point to "like himself."
- b (17:5) Verse 5 is lacking in Swete's text; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII), which counts the five senses as powers given by the Lord. So also verses 16, 18, and 21 below.
- c (17:8) GII adds: "and he granted them to boast of his wonders to the age."

- d (17:9) Swete's text, like the NRSV, has verses 9 and 10 in the reverse order; they are given here in numerical order.
- e (17:17) Compare Deut 32:8–9 in the Greek, where the nations are allotted "according to the number of the angels of God."

Chapter 18

1 The one who lives to the age created all things alike;[a]
2 the Lord alone will be declared righteous.
3 [He steers the world by the span of his hand,
and all things obey his will;
for he is king of all things by his might,
setting apart among them the holy from the common.][b]
4 To no one has he given leave to declare his works;
and who will track out his mighty acts?
5 The strength of his greatness — who will count it up?
And who will go on to tell out his mercies?
6 One cannot take away or add,
and one cannot track out the wonders of the Lord.
7 When a person has finished, then he is beginning,
and when he leaves off, then he will be at a loss.
8 What is a human being, and what is he good for?
What is his good, and what is his evil?
9 The number of a man's days — a hundred years is many.[c]
10 Like a drop of water from the sea and a pebble of sand,
so are a few years set in the day of the age.
11 That is why the Lord bears long with them
and lavishes his mercy upon them.
12 He saw and recognized that their overthrow is wretched;
therefore he made his atonement abundant.
13 A person's mercy is toward his neighbor,
but the Lord's mercy is toward all flesh;
he reproves and trains and teaches
and turns them back, as a shepherd his flock.
14 He has mercy on those who welcome discipline
and who hurry toward his judgments.

15 Child, do not attach blame to good deeds,
or the grief of words to any gift.
16 Will the dew not cool the burning wind?
Just so, a word is better than a gift.
17 See — is not a word above a good gift?
And both are found with a gracious man.
18 A fool reproaches without grace,
and a begrudging man's gift makes the eyes waste away.
19 Before you speak, learn,
and before sickness, look after yourself.
20 Before judgment, examine yourself,
and in the hour of visitation you will find atonement.
21 Before you fall ill, humble yourself,
and in the season of sins, show a turning back.
22 Let nothing keep you from paying a vow in its season,
and do not wait until death to be set right.
23 Before you vow, make yourself ready,
and do not be like a man who puts the Lord to the test.
24 Remember the wrath of the end days
and the season of vengeance, when he turns away his face.
25 Remember the time of hunger in the time of fullness,
poverty and want in days of riches.
26 From dawn until dusk the season shifts,
and all things are quick before the Lord.
27 A wise man will be wary in everything,
and in days of sinning he will guard against offense.
28 Every man of understanding knows wisdom,
and to the one who finds her he will give acknowledgment.
29 Those with understanding in sayings have themselves become wise
and have poured out apt proverbs.
30 Do not walk behind your desires,
and keep yourself back from your cravings.
31 If you grant your soul the good pleasure of desire,
it will make you a thing for your enemies to gloat over.

32 Do not take delight in much luxury,
and do not be bound to its outlay.
33 Do not become a beggar by feasting on borrowed money
when you have nothing in your purse.[d]

Notes

- a (18:1) Greek koinē, “in common,” “alike”; the Latin reads “all at once.”
- b (18:3) Verse 3 is lacking in Swete’s text; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII).
- c (18:9) GII adds: “but no one can reckon the sleep of each one in eternity.”
- d (18:33) GII adds: “for you will be plotting against your own life.”

Chapter 19

1 A laborer who is a drunkard will not grow rich;
one who scorns small things will fall little by little.
2 Wine and women make men of understanding fall away,
and one who cleaves to prostitutes grows more brazen.
3 Rot and worms will inherit him,
and a brazen soul will be taken off.
4 One who trusts quickly is light of heart,
and one who sins will offend against his own soul.
5 One who takes delight in his heart will be condemned,[a]
6 and one who hates chatter has less of evil.
7 Never repeat a word,
and you will be none the worse.
8 To friend or to foe do not tell it,
and unless it is a sin for you, do not uncover it;
9 for he has heard you and kept watch on you,
and in due season he will hate you.
10 Have you heard a word? Let it die with you.
Take heart; it will not burst you.
11 Over a word a fool goes into labor,
like a woman in labor over her infant.
12 An arrow fixed in the flesh of the thigh —
so is a word in a fool’s belly.

13 Reprove a friend: perhaps he did not do it;
and if he did something, so that he does not add to it.
14 Reprove a neighbor: perhaps he did not say it;
and if he has said it, so that he does not say it again.
15 Reprove a friend, for it is often slander,
and do not believe every word.
16 There is one who slips, but not from the soul;
and who has not offended with his tongue?
17 Reprove your neighbor before you threaten,
and give place to the law of the Most High.
18 [The fear of the Lord is where acceptance begins,
and wisdom wins his love.][b]
19 [Knowing the Lord's commandments is a discipline that gives life,
and those who do what pleases him pluck the fruit of the tree of deathlessness.]
20 The whole of wisdom is the fear of the Lord,
and every wisdom includes carrying out the law.
21 [When a slave tells his master, "I will not do as you please,"
even if he does it afterward, he angers the one who feeds him.]
22 Knowing evil is not wisdom,
and where sinners counsel there is no good sense.
23 There is a craftiness, and it is an abomination,
and there is a fool who merely lacks wisdom.
24 Better one who falls short in understanding and is God-fearing
than one who abounds in good sense and steps over the law.
25 There is a cleverness that is exact and unjust,
and there is one who twists a favor to bring a judgment to light.
26 There is a wicked man who goes bent over in black,
and his insides are full of deceit;
27 he lowers his face and plays deaf,
but where he is not noticed he will get the jump on you;
28 and if for lack of strength he is kept from sinning,
when he finds the season he will do harm.

29 From his look a man is known,
and from meeting his face a man of understanding is known.
30 A man's dress and the grin of his teeth
and the steps he takes report what he is.

Notes

- a (19:5) GII adds: "but one who resists pleasures crowns his life." Verse 5b and part of verse 6 in older English versions also come from GII.
- b (19:18) Verses 18, 19, and 21 are lacking in Swete's text; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII).

Chapter 20

1 There is a reproof that is out of season,
and there is one who keeps silent, and he is shrewd.
2 How much better to reprove than to nurse anger!
3 And one who confesses will be kept from loss.
4 A eunuch's lust to deflower a girl —
such is one who works out judgments by force.
5 There is one who keeps silent and is found wise,
and there is one who is hated for great chatter.
6 There is one who keeps silent, for he has no answer,
and there is one who keeps silent, knowing the season.
7 A wise man will hold his peace until the season,
but a boaster and a fool will overshoot the season.
8 One who multiplies words will be loathed,
and one who takes power to himself will be hated.
9 There is good luck for a man in bad things,
and there is a windfall that turns to loss.
10 There is a gift that will not profit you,
and there is a gift whose repayment is double.
11 There is a loss on account of glory,
and there is one who has raised his head from low estate.
12 There is one who buys much for little
and pays for it sevenfold.
13 The wise in speech makes himself loved,
but the graces of fools will be poured out for nothing.

14 A senseless man's gift will not profit you,
for his eyes are many instead of one.[a]
15 He will give little and reproach much,
and he will open his mouth like a town crier;
today he will lend, and tomorrow he will ask it back;
a hateful man is such a one.
16 The fool says, "I have no friends,
and my good deeds earn no thanks;
the people who eat my bread speak evil."
17 How often, and by how many, will he be laughed to scorn!
18 A slip on the pavement is better than one with the tongue;
so the fall of the wicked will come swiftly.
19 A graceless man is a tale told out of season;
it will be always in the mouth of the unschooled.
20 A proverb from a fool's mouth will be refused,
for he will not say it in its season.
21 There is one who is kept from sinning by want,
and at his rest he will not be pricked.
22 There is one who ruins his soul through shame
and ruins it before a senseless face.
23 There is one who from shame makes promises to a friend
and has gained him as an enemy for nothing.
24 A lie is a foul blemish on a man;
it will be always in the mouth of the unschooled.
25 A thief is preferable to one who lies constantly,
but both of them will inherit ruin.
26 The way of a liar is dishonor,
and his shame is with him always.
27 One wise in sayings will advance himself,
and a shrewd man will please the great.
28 One who works the ground will heap his threshing floor high,
and one who pleases the great will atone for injustice.
29 Presents and gifts blind the eyes of the wise,
and like a muzzle on the mouth they turn reproofs aside.

30 Wisdom hidden and treasure out of sight —
what profit is in either?
31 Better a man who hides his folly
than a man who hides his wisdom.

Notes

- a (20:14) That is, he looks for much in return.

Chapter 21

1 Child, have you sinned? Do it no more,
and make supplication about your former sins.
2 As from the face of a snake, flee from sin;
for if you go near, it will bite you;
its teeth are a lion's teeth,
slaying the souls of people.
3 All lawlessness is like a two-edged sword;
its wound has no healing.
4 Panic and insolence will lay waste riches;
so the house of the proud will be laid waste.
5 A poor man's supplication goes from his mouth to his ears,[a]
and his judgment comes in haste.
6 One who hates reproof walks in the sinner's track,
but one who fears the Lord will turn back in his heart.
7 The mighty in tongue is known from far off,
but the man of understanding knows when he slips.
8 One who builds his house with other people's money
is like one gathering stones for his own grave mound.[b]
9 Tow heaped together is a gathering of the lawless,
and their end is a flame of fire.
10 The road of sinners is smoothed with paving stones,
and at its end is the pit of Hades.
11 One who keeps the law masters its intent,
and the completion of the fear of the Lord is wisdom.
12 One who is not clever will not be schooled,
but there is a cleverness that multiplies bitterness.

13 A wise man's knowledge will swell like a flood,
and his counsel like a spring of life.
14 A fool's insides are like a broken jar;
he will hold no knowledge.
15 If a knowing man hears a wise word,
he will praise it and add to it;
the self-indulgent man heard it, and it displeased him,
and he cast it away behind his back.
16 A fool's narration is like a load on the road,
but on the lips of the understanding grace will be found.
17 People will look to the shrewd for a word in the assembly,
and will turn his words over in their minds.
18 Like a house laid waste, so is wisdom to a fool,
and the knowledge of the witless is talk no one can test.
19 Fetters on the feet is discipline to the senseless,
and like manacles on the right hand.
20 A fool lifts up his voice in laughter,
but a clever man will scarcely smile, and quietly.
21 Like a golden ornament is discipline to the shrewd,
and like a bracelet on the right arm.
22 A fool's foot is quick into a house,
but a man of experience is abashed before a face.
23 A senseless man peeps from the door into a house,
but a well-schooled man will stand outside.
24 It is bad schooling for a man to listen at a door;
the shrewd man would be weighed down with the dishonor.
25 The lips of strangers will be heavy with these things,[c]
but the words of the understanding are weighed on the scale.
26 In fools' mouths is their heart,
but in the heart of the wise is their mouth.
27 When the ungodly man curses Satan,
he curses his own soul.[d]
28 The whisperer stains his own soul
and will be hated in his neighborhood.

Notes

- a (21:5) That is, to God's ears.
- b (21:8) So some witnesses (chōma); others read "for winter" (cheimōna).
- c (21:25) The Greek of the first line is uncertain; some witnesses read "the lips of the talkative."
- d (21:27) Greek satanas, "the adversary"; the sense may be that the wicked, in cursing his opponent, calls the curse down on himself.

Chapter 22

1 A filthy stone — that is what the idler is like,
and everyone will hiss at his disgrace.
2 A lump of dung — that is what the idler is like;
everyone who picks it up will shake off his hand.
3 Shame for a father is an unschooled son,
and a daughter is born to his loss.
4 A shrewd daughter will inherit a husband of her own,
but she who brings shame is a grief to the one who sired her.
5 A brazen daughter shames father and husband,
and by both she will be held in dishonor.
6 Like music in mourning is a tale out of season,
but whips and discipline are wisdom in every season.
7 [Children brought up to a good life
cover the humble birth of their parents.][a]
8 [Children who swell with contempt and coarseness from lack of training
stain the noble birth of their kin.]
9 One who teaches a fool is gluing a potsherd,
rousing a sleeper out of deep sleep.
10 One who narrates to a fool narrates to a man who is nodding off,
and at the end he will say, "What is it?"
11 Weep over a dead man, for light has failed him,
and weep over a fool, for understanding has failed him;
weep more gently over a dead man, for he has gone to rest,
but the fool's life is worse than death.
12 For the dead, mourning lasts seven days;
for the fool and the ungodly, every day he lives.

13 Do not multiply talk with a senseless man,
and do not go along with one who has no understanding;
guard yourself from him, so that you have no trouble
and are not smeared when he shakes himself;
turn aside from him, and you will find rest
and will not be worn out by his madness.
14 What will be heavier than lead?
And what is its name but "Fool"?
15 Sand and salt and a lump of iron
are easier to carry than a man without understanding.
16 Wooden binding fastened into a building
will not be loosed by a quake;
just so, a heart fixed on considered counsel
will not cower at the critical moment.
17 A heart set firm on thoughts of understanding
is like plaster ornament on a smooth wall.
18 Stakes standing on a height[b]
will not hold against the wind;
just so, a cowering heart, with a fool's thoughts,
will not hold against any fear.
19 One who pricks an eye will bring down tears,
and one who pricks a heart brings its feeling to light.
20 One who throws a stone at birds scares them off,
and one who reviles a friend will dissolve the friendship.
21 Even if you have drawn a sword on a friend,
do not despair, for there can be a way back.
22 If you have opened your mouth against a friend,
do not be anxious, for there can be reconciliation —
except for reproach and arrogance, the uncovering of a secret, and a treacherous blow;
at these any friend will run away.
23 Gain trust with your neighbor in his poverty,
so that in his good things you may be filled together;
stay by him in the season of his affliction,
so that you may share in his inheritance together.

24 Ahead of fire comes the steam of a furnace and smoke;
just so, abuse comes ahead of bloodshed.
25 I will not be ashamed to shelter a friend,
and from his face I will not hide.
26 And if evil happens to me through him,
everyone who hears will be on guard against him.
27 Who will set a guard upon my mouth
and a seal of shrewdness upon my lips,
so that I do not fall by them
and my tongue does not destroy me?

Notes

- a (22:7) Verses 7 and 8 are lacking in Swete's text; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII).
- b (22:18) Greek charakes, "stakes"; some witnesses read "pebbles."

Chapter 23

1 O Lord, Father and Master of my life,
do not leave me to their counsel;
do not let me fall by them.
2 Who will set whips over my thinking
and wisdom's discipline over my heart,
that they may not spare my failings
and not let their sins pass by?
3 So that my failings do not multiply
and my sins do not abound,
and I fall before those who oppose me,
and my enemy gloats over me.
4 O Lord, Father and God of my life,
do not give me lofty eyes,
5 and turn desire away from me.
6 Do not let gluttony and lust lay hold of me,
and do not hand me over to a shameless soul.
7 Hear, children, discipline of the mouth;
the one who keeps it will never be caught.

8 By his lips the sinner will be overtaken,
and the reviler and the proud will stumble by them.
9 Do not train your mouth to oaths,
and do not make a habit of naming the Holy One.
10 For as a household slave who is examined continually
will not be free of welts,
so too one who swears and names the Name at all times
will never be cleansed of sin.
11 A man of many oaths will be filled with lawlessness,
and the whip will not leave his house;
if he offends, his sin is on him,
and if he overlooks it, he has sinned twice;
and if he has sworn idly, he will not be declared righteous,
for his house will be filled with calamities.
12 There is a kind of speech clothed with death;[a]
let it not be found in the inheritance of Jacob!
For all these things will be kept far from the godly,
and they will not roll about in sins.
13 Do not train your mouth to coarse filthiness,
for in it is a word of sin.
14 Call to mind your father and your mother,
for you sit among great men,
so that you do not forget yourself in their sight
and play the fool by your habit,
and wish you had not been born,
and curse the day of your birth.
15 A man trained in words of reproach
will not be schooled in all his days.
16 Two kinds multiply sins,
and the third will bring on wrath:
a hot soul, like a blazing fire,
will not be quenched until it is swallowed up;
a man who fornicates with the body of his own flesh
will not cease until the fire burns him up.

17 To a fornicating man all bread is sweet;
he will not let up until he comes to his end.
18 A man who strays from his own bed
says in his soul, “Who sees me?
Darkness is around me, and the walls cover me,
and no one sees me; what have I to be wary of?
The Most High will not remember my sins.”
19 What he fears is human eyes,
and he has not grasped that the Lord’s eyes
outshine the sun ten thousandfold,
gazing on all the ways of human beings
and peering into hidden corners.
20 Before all things were created, they were known to him,
and so also after their completion.
21 This man will be punished in the streets of the city,
and where he did not suspect, he will be caught.
22 So also a wife who leaves her husband
and produces an heir by a stranger.
23 For first, she disobeyed the law of the Most High;
second, she offended against her husband;
third, she committed adultery in fornication
and produced children by a strange man.
24 She will be led out into the assembly,
and a visitation will come upon her children.
25 Her children will not spread into roots,
and her branches will not bear fruit.
26 She will leave behind her memory for a curse,
and her disgrace will not be wiped away.
27 Those who survive will realize
that there is nothing better than reverence for the Lord,
and nothing sweeter than keeping the Lord’s commandments.[b]

Notes

- a (23:12) Probably blasphemy, which carried the death penalty (Lev 24:16).
- b (23:27) GII adds a verse (23:28): “It is great glory to follow God, and to be received by him is length of days.”

Chapter 24

The Praise of Wisdom

1 Wisdom will sing her own soul's praise
and will boast in the midst of her people.
2 Within the gathering of the Most High her mouth will open,
and facing his armies she will make her boast:
3 "From the mouth of the Most High I came forth,
and like a mist I covered the earth.
4 In the heights I pitched my tent,
and my throne was in a pillar of cloud.
5 The vault of heaven I circled alone,
and in the depth of the abysses I walked about.
6 Over the sea's waves and over the whole earth,
over every people and nation, I took possession.
7 Among all these I sought rest:
in whose inheritance would I lodge?
8 Then the Creator of all things gave me command,
and the One who created me made my tent rest,
and he said, 'In Jacob pitch your tent,
and in Israel receive your inheritance.'
9 Before the age, from the beginning, he created me,
and to the age I will never fail.
10 In the holy tent I ministered before him,
and so in Zion I was set firm.
11 In the beloved city he likewise gave me rest,
and in Jerusalem was my authority.
12 I struck root among a people given glory,
in the Lord's portion, his inheritance.
13 Like a cedar in Lebanon I was raised high,
and like a cypress on the mountains of Hermon.
14 Like a palm in En-gedi[a] I was raised high,
and like rose bushes in Jericho,
like a comely olive in the plain,
and like a plane tree I was raised high.

15 Like cinnamon and camel's thorn I gave off the fragrance of spices,
and like choice myrrh I spread a sweet scent,
like galbanum and onycha and stacte,
and like the vapor of frankincense in the tent.[b]
16 Like a terebinth I stretched out my branches,
and my branches are branches of glory and grace.
17 Like a vine I put forth grace,
and my blossoms became the fruit of glory and riches.
18 [I am mother of beautiful love and of fear,
of knowledge and of holy hope;
everlasting, I am given to all my children,
to those he has named.][c]
19 Come over to me, you who long for me,
and be filled from my produce.
20 For to remember me is sweeter than honey,
and to inherit me, sweeter than the comb of honey.
21 Those who eat me will still be hungry,
and those who drink me will still be thirsty.
22 Whoever obeys me will never be ashamed,
and whoever works with my help will not sin."
23 All these things are the book of the covenant of God Most High,
a law that Moses commanded us,
an inheritance for the gatherings of Jacob.[d]
24 [Do not grow faint in being strong in the Lord;
hold fast to him, that he may give you strength;
the Lord Almighty is God alone,
and there is no savior other than he.]
25 It is the law that brims with wisdom like the Pishon,[e]
and like the Tigris in the days of first fruits;
26 that makes understanding run over like the Euphrates,
and like the Jordan in the days of harvest;
27 that makes discipline shine out like light,[f]
like the Gihon in the days of vintage.

28 The first man did not finish knowing her,
and so the last will not track her out.
29 For her thinking is fuller than the sea,
and her counsel than the great abyss.
30 And I was like a channel out of a river,
like a watercourse into a garden.
31 I said, "I will water my garden
and soak my flower bed";
and look — my channel became a river,
and my river became a sea.
32 Still more I will make discipline shine like the dawn,
and I will make it appear far off.
33 Still more I will pour out teaching like prophecy
and leave it behind for generations of the ages.
34 See: I have not toiled for myself alone,
but for all who seek her out.

Notes

- a (24:14) So some Greek witnesses (Engaddi); others read "on the beaches."
- b (24:15) These are the ingredients of the sacred anointing oil and incense (Exod 30:23–34).
- c (24:18) Verses 18 and 24 are lacking in Swete's text; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII).
- d (24:23) Quoting Deut 33:4. Sirach is the first known writer to identify Wisdom with the Torah outright.
- e (24:25) Pishon, Tigris, Euphrates, and Gihon are the rivers of Eden (Gen 2:10–14).
- f (24:27) "Like light" is probably a misreading of a Hebrew word for "like the Nile" (ye'or read as 'or).

Chapter 25

1 In three things I was made beautiful,
and I stood up in beauty before the Lord and people:[a]
harmony of brothers, and friendship of neighbors,
and wife and husband suited to each other.
2 Three kinds my soul hated,
and I am deeply offended at their life:

a poor man who is proud, a rich man who lies,
an old adulterer who lacks understanding.
3 If you did not gather in your youth,
how will you find in your old age?
4 How lovely is judgment in gray hair,
and for elders to know counsel!
5 How lovely is wisdom in the old,
and understanding and counsel in those given glory!
6 The crown of the old is wide experience,
and their boast is the fear of the Lord.
7 Nine notions I count blessed in my heart,
and the tenth I will utter with my tongue:
a man gladdened by his children;
one who lives to see the fall of his enemies;
8 blessed is he who dwells with a wife of understanding,
and he who has not slipped with his tongue,[b]
and he who has not served someone unworthy of him;
9 blessed is he who has found good sense,
and he who tells his story into listening ears.
10 How great is he who has found wisdom!
But none is above the one who fears the Lord.
11 The fear of the Lord rises above all things;
to whom will the one who holds it be likened?
12 [The fear of the Lord is where loving him begins,
and faith is where clinging to him begins.][c]
13 Any wound, only not a wound of the heart!
Any wickedness, only not the wickedness of a wife!
14 Any assault, only not from those who hate!
Any vengeance, only not from enemies!
15 There is no head above a snake's head,[d]
and no wrath above an enemy's wrath.
16 I would sooner make my home with a lion and a dragon
than make my home with an evil wife.

17 A wife's wickedness alters her look
and darkens her face like a bear's.
18 Her husband takes his seat among his neighbors,
and he cannot help sighing bitterly.
19 Small is any wickedness beside a wife's wickedness;
may a sinner's lot fall upon her!
20 A sandy climb for an old man's feet —
so is a wife full of tongue to a quiet husband.
21 Do not fall headlong for a woman's beauty,
and do not set your longing on a woman.
22 There is wrath and brazenness and great disgrace
when a wife provides for her husband.
23 A heart brought low, a sullen face,
a wounded heart — so is an evil wife;
slack hands and buckling knees —
so is she who does not make her husband blessed.
24 With a woman sin made its start,[e]
and on her account we all die.
25 Do not give water an outlet,
or an evil wife freedom of speech.
26 If she does not walk at your hand,
cut her away from your flesh.[f]

Notes

- a (25:1) The Greek of the first line is uncertain; some witnesses read "In three things my soul took delight."
- b (25:8) The Hebrew, as reported, adds here "and who does not plow with an ox and an ass together" (compare Deut 22:10).
- c (25:12) Verse 12 is lacking in Swete's text; it belongs to the longer Greek recension (GII).
- d (25:15) The Hebrew word rosh means both "head" and "venom"; the Greek has taken the first sense.
- e (25:24) Usually taken as a reference to Eve (Gen 3); some interpreters, as reported, take it of the evil wife of the context.
- f (25:26) That is, divorce her (compare Deut 24:1).

Chapter 26

1 A good wife — her husband is blessed;
the count of his days is doubled.
2 A brave wife gladdens her husband,
and he will fill out his years in peace.
3 A good wife is a good portion;
she will be given as a portion to those who fear the Lord.
4 Be he rich or poor, his heart is good,
and his face is cheerful in every season.
5 Of three things my heart was in dread,
and over the fourth I made supplication:[a]
slander in a city, a mob's gathering,
and false accusation — all are more grievous than death.
6 But pain of heart and mourning is a wife jealous of a wife,
and a tongue's whip that shares itself with all.
7 A yoke of oxen jolted about is an evil wife;
one who takes hold of her is like one gripping a scorpion.
8 Great wrath is a drunken wife;
she will not cover her own disgrace.
9 A wife's fornication shows in the lifting of her eyes,
and by her eyelids it will be known.
10 Over a headstrong daughter set a firm guard,
so that, finding license, she does not make use of it.
11 Keep watch behind a brazen eye,
and do not wonder if it offends against you.
12 Like a thirsty traveler she will open her mouth
and drink from any water near at hand;
she will sit down facing every peg
and open her quiver to every arrow.
13 A wife's grace delights her husband,
and her knowing will put fat on his bones.
14 A silent wife is a gift of the Lord,
and nothing can be traded for a well-schooled soul.

15 Grace upon grace is a modest wife,
and nothing can weigh the worth of a self-controlled soul.
16 As the sun rising in the heights of the Lord,
so is a good wife's beauty in the ordering of her house.
17 As a lamp shining on the holy lampstand,[b]
so is the beauty of a face on a steady frame.
18 As golden pillars on a silver base,
so are lovely legs on firm heels.
19 [Child, guard the bloom of your age in health,
and do not give your strength to strangers.[c]
20 Seek out a fertile plot from all the plain,
and sow your own seed there, trusting in your good birth.
21 So your offspring will survive you
and grow great, confident in their good birth.
22 A hired woman is reckoned as spittle,
but a married woman is a tower of death to those who use her.
23 A godless wife is given as the portion of a lawless man,
but a devout wife is given to one who fears the Lord.
24 A shameless woman wears disgrace thin,
but a modest daughter will be abashed even before her husband.
25 A wife without shame will be counted as a dog,
but she who has modesty will stand in fear of the Lord.
26 A wife who honors her husband will appear wise to all,
but one who dishonors him in her pride will be known to all as ungodly.
Blessed is the husband of a good wife,
for the count of his years will be doubled.
27 A wife who shouts and chatters
is like a war trumpet sounding to rout the enemy,
and every man in such a case spends his life amid the uproar of war.]
28 At two things my heart is grieved,
and at the third, wrath has come over me:
a fighting man in want from poverty,

and men of understanding counted as refuse,
and one who turns back from righteousness to sin —
the Lord will make him ready for the sword.
29 Hardly will a trader keep himself from going wrong,
and a shopkeeper will not be declared free of sin.

Notes

- a (26:5) So most witnesses; Swete's text has "my face was in dread."
- b (26:17) The lampstand of the sanctuary (Exod 25:31–40).
- c (26:19) Verses 19–27 are lacking in Swete's text and the oldest Greek witnesses; they belong to the longer Greek recension (GII) and are found also in the Syriac, as reported.

Chapter 27

1 Many have sinned for a thing of no account,
and one who seeks to grow rich will turn his eye away.
2 Between the joints of stones a peg is driven fast,
and between selling and buying sin is ground in.
3 If one does not hold on to the fear of the Lord with zeal,
his house will be overturned in haste.
4 When a sieve is shaken, the refuse stays behind;
so a man's filth stays in his reasoning.
5 The furnace tests the potter's vessels,
and a man's trial is in his reasoning.
6 Fruit lays bare the tending of a tree;
so the speech that expresses a thought lays bare a man's heart.
7 Before he reasons aloud, do not praise a man,
for this is the trial of people.
8 If you pursue what is right, you will overtake it
and put it on like a long robe of glory.
9 Birds will lodge with their like,
and truth will come back to those who work it.
10 A lion lies in ambush for prey;
so sin for those who work injustice.
11 The talk of a godly man is wisdom at all times,
but the fool alters like the moon.

12 Among the witless, watch the season,
but among the thoughtful, linger.
13 The talk of fools is a provocation,
and their laughter is in the wantonness of sin.
14 The talk of a man of many oaths makes the hair stand up,
and at their brawling one stops one's ears.
15 Bloodshed is the brawling of the proud,
and their abuse is a grievous hearing.
16 One who uncovers secrets has destroyed trust
and will never find a friend for his soul.
17 Hold a friend dear and keep faith with him;
but if you uncover his secrets, do not chase after him.
18 For as a man has destroyed his dead enemy,
so you have destroyed your neighbor's friendship.
19 And as a bird you let loose from your hand,
so you have let your neighbor go, and you will not hunt him down.
20 Do not chase him, for he is far off
and has fled like a gazelle out of the snare.
21 For a wound there is binding up,
and for abuse there is reconciliation,
but one who uncovers secrets has lost hope.
22 One who winks with the eye is crafting evil,
and no one will turn him from it.
23 In your sight his mouth will be sweet,
and at your words he will wonder;
but afterward he will twist his mouth
and lay a stumbling block in your words.
24 Many things I have hated, but nothing to match him;
and the Lord will hate him.
25 One who throws a stone on high throws it on his own head,
and a treacherous blow deals out wounds.
26 One who digs a pit will fall into it,
and one who sets a trap will be caught in it.

27 One who works evil — it will roll back on him,
and he will not know where it came from.
28 Mockery and abuse belong to the arrogant,
and vengeance lies in ambush for him like a lion.
29 Those who gloat at the fall of the godly will be caught in a trap,
and pain will eat them up before their death.
30 Wrath and anger, these too are abominations,
and the sinful man will cling to them.

Chapter 28

1 One who takes vengeance will meet vengeance from the Lord,
and he will keep strict count of his sins.
2 Release your neighbor from the wrong he did,
and then, when you pray, your sins will be released.
3 Does a man keep his wrath against a man
and seek healing from the Lord?
4 On a man like himself he has no mercy,
and he makes supplication about his own sins?
5 He, being flesh, keeps up his rage;
who will atone for his sins?
6 Remember the last things, and leave off enmity;
remember decay and death, and stand by the commandments.
7 Remember the commandments, and do not rage at your neighbor;
remember the covenant of the Most High, and overlook ignorance.
8 Keep away from strife, and you will make sins fewer;
for a hot-tempered man will kindle strife,
9 and a sinful man will throw friends into turmoil
and cast accusation among those at peace.
10 As is the wood of the fire, so it will blaze;
and as is the stubbornness of strife, so it will blaze;
as a man's strength is, so will his wrath be,
and in proportion to his riches he will raise his anger.
11 A hurried quarrel kindles fire,
and a hurried fight pours out blood.

12 If you blow on a spark, it will flare,
and if you spit on it, it will go out;
and both come out of your mouth.
13 Curse the whisperer and the double-tongued,
for they have destroyed many who were at peace.
14 The third tongue[a] has shaken many people
and driven them from one nation to another;
it has pulled down strong cities
and overturned the homes of the great.
15 A third tongue has driven brave wives from home
and robbed them of their labors.
16 Whoever heeds it will find no rest
and will not make his dwelling in quiet.
17 The stroke of a whip makes a welt,
but the stroke of a tongue will crush bones.
18 Many have fallen by the sword's mouth,
yet not so many as those who have fallen by the tongue.
19 Blessed is he who is sheltered from it,
who has not passed through its rage,
who has not drawn its yoke
and has not been bound in its fetters.
20 For its yoke is an iron yoke,
and its fetters are bronze fetters.
21 Its death is an evil death,
and Hades is to be preferred to it.
22 It will not get the mastery of the godly,
and in its flame they will not be burned.
23 Those who abandon the Lord will fall into it,
and in them it will blaze and not be quenched;
it will be sent out on them like a lion,
and like a leopard it will maul them.
24 See, you hedge your property with thorns;
bind up your silver and your gold.

25 So make a balance and a weight for your words,
and make a door and a bar for your mouth.
26 Take care not to slip by it,
or you will fall before one lying in ambush.

Notes

- a (28:14) A Hebrew idiom for slander: the tongue of a third party that comes between two.

Chapter 29

1 One who acts mercifully will lend to his neighbor,
and one who props him up with his hand keeps the commandments.
2 Lend to your neighbor in the season of his need,
and pay your neighbor back again at the proper season.
3 Make your word firm and keep faith with him,
and at every season you will find what you need.
4 Many have counted a loan as a windfall
and made trouble for those who stood by them.
5 Until he receives, he will kiss a man's hands,
and he will lower his voice over his neighbor's money;
but at the time for repayment he will drag out the time
and pay back words of indifference
and lay the blame on the season.
6 If he can pay, the lender will scarcely get half
and will count it a windfall;
if not, he has been robbed of his money
and has gained an enemy for nothing;
curses and abuse are the repayment he gets,
and instead of glory, dishonor.
7 Many, then, have refused to lend, not out of wickedness;
they were afraid of being robbed for nothing.
8 Yet with a man in low estate be patient,
and do not make him wait on your alms.
9 For the commandment's sake take the part of a poor man,
and in his need do not send him away empty.

10 Lose silver for a brother and a friend,
and do not let it rust under a stone to be lost.
11 Store up your treasure according to the commandments of the Most High,
and it will benefit you more than gold.
12 Shut almsgiving up in your storehouses,
and it will rescue you from every evil;
13 more than a stout shield and a heavy spear,
it will fight for you in the face of the enemy.
14 A good man will stand surety for his neighbor,
but one who has lost his shame will abandon him.
15 Do not forget the favors of your guarantor,
for he gave his soul for you.
16 A sinner will squander the good things of his guarantor,
17 and one ungrateful at heart will abandon his rescuer.
18 Pledging security for others has ruined many who prospered
and tossed them about like a wave at sea;
it has driven powerful men out of their homes,
and they have wandered among foreign peoples.
19 A sinner who falls into suretyship
and goes after business deals will fall into lawsuits.
20 Take your neighbor's part as far as your strength allows,
and look to yourself, so that you do not fall.
21 The basic necessities of life are water and bread,
clothing, and a house to shelter one from shame.
22 Better a poor man's life under a shelter of beams
than splendid fare in other people's houses.
23 With little or with much, be well content.
24 A wretched life it is to go from house to house,
and where you are a sojourner you will not open your mouth.
25 You will play host and pour drink to no thanks,
and on top of this you will hear bitter things:
26 "Come here, sojourner, set the table,
and if you have anything at hand, feed me."

27 "Get out, sojourner, before one given glory;
my brother has come to lodge with me; I need the house."
28 These things are hard on a man of understanding:
reproach over lodging and the scorn of the creditor.

Chapter 30

1 One who loves his son will keep the whip on him,
so that he may be glad over him at the last.
2 One who disciplines his son will have joy of him
and will boast of him among his acquaintances.
3 One who teaches his son will rouse his enemy's jealousy
and will exult over him before his friends.
4 His father has come to his end, and it is as though he had not died,
for he has left behind one like himself.
5 In his life he saw and was glad,
and in his end he was not grieved.
6 He has left behind an avenger against his enemies
and one to repay favors to his friends.
7 One who pampers his son will be binding up his wounds,
and at every cry his insides will churn.
8 An unbroken horse turns out hard,
and a son let loose turns out headlong.
9 Coddle a child, and he will make you dread him;
play with him, and he will grieve you.
10 Do not laugh along with him, so that you do not ache along with him
and grind your teeth at the last.
11 Do not give him authority in his youth.[a]
12 Bend his neck in youth
and bruise his ribs while he is a child,
so that he does not grow hard and disobey you.
13 Discipline your son and work at him,
so that you do not stumble over his indecency.
14 Better a poor man, healthy and strong in constitution,
than a rich man whipped in his body.

15 Health and sound condition are better than all gold,
and a robust body than riches beyond count.
16 No riches are better than a healthy body,
and no joy is greater than a joyful heart.
17 Better death than a bitter life,
or rest to the age than lingering sickness.
18 Good things poured over a closed mouth
are like portions of food laid on a grave.
19 What good is an offering to an idol?
For it will neither eat nor smell.
So is the one whom the Lord is pursuing:
20 with his eyes he looks on, and he moans,
as a eunuch moans who holds a virgin in his arms.
21 Do not give your soul over to grief,
and do not afflict yourself by your own counsel.
22 Gladness of heart is the life of a man,
and a man's exultation is length of days.
23 Coax your soul and comfort your heart,
and drive grief far away from you;
for grief has destroyed many,
and there is no profit in it.
24 Jealousy and rage shorten days,
and worry brings old age before its season.
25 A bright and good heart at table
will take care over its food.[b]

Notes

- a (30:11) GII adds: "and do not overlook his follies." In verse 12 the first line also comes from GII.
- b (30:25) At this point the Greek manuscripts have suffered a transposition: in all of them, 30:25–33:13a (NRSV numbering) stands after 33:13b–36:16a. The Hebrew and the Latin preserve the original order, which is followed here, as in most modern versions. Swete prints the Greek in the transposed order; his chapter and verse numbers for this section therefore differ.

Chapter 31

1 Wakefulness over wealth melts the flesh away,
and the worry it brings drives off sleep.
2 Wakeful worry will keep slumber away,
and a heavy sickness will snatch sleep off.
3 A rich man toils at heaping up money,
and when he rests he is filled with his delicacies.
4 A poor man toils at the lack of a livelihood,
and when he rests he becomes needy.
5 One who loves gold will not be counted righteous,
and one who pursues gain will be filled with it.[a]
6 Many have been handed over to ruin for the sake of gold,
and their destruction stood in front of their face.
7 It is a timber to trip over for those who pour out offerings to it,
and every witless man will be caught by it.
8 Blessed is the rich man who has been found blameless,
who has not gone running after gold.
9 Who is he, that we may call him blessed?
For he has done wonders among his people.
10 Who has been put to the proof by it and found complete?
Let it be his boast.
Who could have transgressed, and did not transgress,
and could have done evil, and did not do it?
11 His good things will be made firm,
and the assembly will tell over his almsgiving.
12 Are you seated at a great table?
Do not open your gullet over it,
and do not say, "What plenty is on it!"
13 Remember that an evil eye is a wicked thing.[b]
What has been created more wicked than an eye?
That is why it sheds tears at every turn.
14 Wherever he looks, do not stretch out your hand,
and do not jostle him in the dish.

15 Judge your neighbor's feelings from your own,
and think over every matter.
16 Eat, as a human being should, what is set before you,
and do not gobble, or you will be detested.
17 For manners' sake be the first to leave off,
and do not be greedy past filling, lest you cause offense.
18 And if you sit in the midst of many,
do not reach out your hand before they do.
19 How enough for a well-schooled man is a little!
And on his bed he does not gasp for breath.
20 Healthy sleep comes with a moderate stomach;
he rises early, and his soul is his own.
The pain of wakefulness and of vomiting
and of griping in the bowels is with the insatiable man.
21 And if you have been pressed into eating too much,
rise up, go out in the middle, and you will have rest.[c]
22 Hear me, child, and do not make light of me,
and in the end you will find out my words;
in all your works be brisk,
and no sickness will come near you.
23 One who is lavish with bread, lips will bless,
and the testimony to his goodness is to be trusted.
24 One who is mean with bread, the city will grumble at,
and the testimony to his meanness is exact.
25 Do not play the hero over wine,
for wine has destroyed many.
26 A furnace proves the tempering of steel by dipping;
so wine proves hearts in the quarreling of the arrogant.
27 Wine is like life to human beings
if you drink it in its measure.
What life is there for one who goes without wine?
It has been created for gladness to human beings.
28 Gladness of heart and good cheer of soul
is wine drunk in its season and to sufficiency.

29 Bitterness of soul is wine drunk to excess,
with provocation and stumbling.
30 Drunkenness swells a fool's rage to his stumbling,
cutting down strength and adding wounds.
31 At a banquet of wine do not reprove your neighbor,
and do not treat him with contempt in his merriment;
speak no word of reproach to him,
and do not press him with demands.

Notes

- a (31:5) The Greek diaphora means both "gain, profit" and "ruin"; the wordplay continues in verse 6.
- b (31:13) An "evil eye" is a greedy or grudging eye.
- c (31:21) The Greek is uncertain; some witnesses read "vomit" (a sense attested in the Hebrew, as reported).

Chapter 32

1 Have they made you master of the feast? Do not be lifted up;
be among them as one of them;
take care of them, and then sit down.
2 And when you have done all your duty, recline,
so that you may be glad on their account
and receive a garland for your good order.
3 Speak, elder, for it is fitting for you,
but with exact knowledge,
and do not get in the way of the music.
4 Where there is listening, do not pour out chatter,
and do not show yourself wise out of season.
5 A seal of carnelian in a setting of gold —
such is a concert of music at a banquet of wine.
6 A seal of emerald in a mounting of gold —
such is the melody of music over pleasant wine.
7 Speak, young man, if there is need of you,
barely twice, if you are asked.
8 Sum up your speech, much in few words;
be like one who knows and yet holds his peace.

9 Among the great do not make yourself their equal,
and where another is speaking, do not prattle much.
10 Lightning hurries ahead of thunder,
and favor goes ahead of a modest man.
11 When the hour comes, get up and do not be the last;
run off home and do not dawdle.
12 There take your amusement and carry out your intentions,
yet do not sin with a proud word.
13 And for these things bless the One who made you
and who makes you drunk with his good things.
14 Whoever fears the Lord will accept correction,
and those who seek him early will win his favor.
15 Whoever searches the law will be satisfied by it,
but the hypocrite will trip over it.
16 Those who fear the Lord will find judgment,
and they will kindle righteous acts like a light.
17 A sinful man turns reproof aside
and finds an interpretation to suit his will.
18 A man of counsel will not overlook a thought;
an alien and proud man does not shrink in fear.[a]
19 Do nothing without counsel,
and when you have acted, do not repent of it.
20 Do not go on a road of conflict,
and do not trip yourself on stony ground.
21 Do not be confident on a road without obstacles,
22 and from your own children be on your guard.[b]
23 In every work keep faith with your own soul,
for this too is the keeping of commandments.
24 One who keeps faith with the law pays heed to commandments,
and one who trusts in the Lord will suffer no loss.

Notes

- a (32:18) GII and some witnesses add "even after he has acted without counsel." The Hebrew of this verse, as reported, differs considerably.
- b (32:22) The Hebrew, as reported, reads "and watch your paths."

Chapter 33

1 No evil will meet one who fears the Lord,
but in trial he will rescue him again and again.
2 A wise man will not hate the law,
but one who is a hypocrite about it is like a boat in a squall.
3 A person of understanding will trust in the law,
and the law is trustworthy to him as an inquiry of the oracle.[a]
4 Get ready what you will say, and so you will be heard;
bind up your learning, and then answer.
5 A fool's insides are a cartwheel,
and his reasoning is like a spinning axle.
6 A stallion for breeding is like a friend who mocks:
he neighs under everyone who sits on him.
7 Why is one day set above another,
when all the light of each day in the year comes from the sun?
8 By the Lord's knowledge they were set apart,
and he varied the seasons and the feasts.
9 Some of them he lifted high and made holy,
and some of them he placed among the count of days.
10 And all human beings are from the ground,
and Adam was created out of earth.
11 In the fullness of his knowledge the Lord set them apart
and made their ways different.
12 Some he blessed and raised to high places,
some he made holy and drew close to himself;
some he cursed and humbled,
and he drove them out of their positions.
13 As the potter's clay is in his hand —
all its ways are as he pleases —
so human beings are in the hand of the One who made them,
to render to them as he judges.[b]
14 Opposite evil stands the good,
and opposite death, life;
so opposite the godly stands the sinner.

15 So consider all the works of the Most High:
they come in pairs, the one set against the other.
16 And I, last of all, kept watch,
like one who gleans behind the grape-gatherers;
17 by the blessing of the Lord I got ahead,
and like a grape-gatherer I filled my winepress.
18 Take note that I have not toiled for myself alone,
but for all who seek discipline.
19 Hear me, you great ones of the people,
and you leaders of the assembly, give ear.
20 To son and wife, to brother and friend,
do not give power over you while you live;
and do not give your goods to another,
so that you do not change your mind and beg for them.
21 While you still live and there is breath in you,
do not trade yourself away to any flesh.
22 For it is better that your children ask of you
than that you look to your sons' hands.
23 In all your works keep the upper hand;
do not put a blemish on your glory.
24 On the day you finish the days of your life,
and in the season of your death, hand out your inheritance.
25 For a donkey, fodder and a rod and burdens;
for a household slave, bread and correction and labor.
26 Put your servant to work, and you will find rest;
let his hands go slack, and he will look for freedom.
27 Yoke and strap will bend the neck,
and for a wicked household slave, the rack and tortures.
28 Send him to work, so that he does not sit idle,
29 for idleness has taught much evil.
30 Set him to the works that befit him,
and if he does not obey, make his fetters heavy.
But do not go beyond measure with any flesh,
and do nothing without judgment.

31 If you have a household slave, let him be as yourself,
for with blood you acquired him.[c]
If you have a household slave, treat him as a brother,
for you will need him as you need your own soul.
32 If you do him harm and he gets up and runs away,
33 on what road will you look for him?

Notes

- a (33:3) Literally "as the asking of Delos," i.e., an oracle; some read "the Urim" (Exod 28:30).
- b (33:13) Here, in the order of the Greek manuscripts, the long section ending at 36:16a is followed by the section beginning at 30:25; see the note at 30:25. The Hebrew order is followed here.
- c (33:31) "With blood" probably means "at great cost"; some take it as "of your own flesh and blood."

Chapter 34

1 Empty and false are the hopes of a man without understanding,
and dreams give wings to fools.
2 Like one grabbing at a shadow and chasing after wind
is one who holds on to dreams.
3 This set against that is the sight of dreams,
the likeness of a face facing a face.[a]
4 From something unclean, what will be cleansed?
And from something false, what will turn out true?
5 Divinings and omens and dreams are empty,
and the heart fancies things as a woman in labor does.
6 If they are not dispatched from the Most High in a visitation,
do not set your heart on them.
7 For dreams have led many astray,
and those who hoped in them have fallen.
8 Without lying the law will be fulfilled,
and wisdom in a faithful mouth is fulfillment.
9 A man who has wandered abroad knows many things,
and one of wide experience will tell out understanding.
10 One who has not been tested knows few things,
11 but one who has wandered will increase his cleverness.

12 Many things I saw in my wanderings,
and more than my words is my understanding.
13 Many times I was in danger even of death,
and I was kept safe because of these things.
14 The spirit of those who fear the Lord will live,
15 because they place their hope in the one who saves them.
16 One who fears the Lord will not shrink in dread
and will not play the coward, for he is his hope.
17 The soul of one who fears the Lord — how blessed it is!
18 To whom does he hold fast? And who is his prop?
19 The Lord's eyes are on those who love him;
he is a powerful protection and a firm support,
a shelter from the burning wind and a shade at noon,
guarding against a stumble and helping when one falls.
20 He lifts up the soul and makes the eyes shine;
he gives healing, life, and blessing.
21 One who sacrifices from what was got by wrong — his offering is a mockery,
22 and the mockeries of the lawless are not welcome.
23 The Most High takes no pleasure in the offerings of the ungodly,
nor does he atone for sins by a multitude of sacrifices.
24 One who brings a sacrifice out of the goods of the poor
is like one who slaughters a son before his father's eyes.
25 Bread of the needy is the life of the poor;
one who robs them of it is a man of blood.
26 One who takes away his neighbor's living murders him,
27 and one who robs a hired man of his wage pours out blood.
28 One man raises a wall and another pulls it down:
what profit do the two have except their labor?
29 One prays and another curses:
whose voice will the Master hear?
30 Someone washes after touching a corpse, then touches it again —
what good has his washing done him?[b]

31 Just so a man fasting over his sins
who turns round and does them over again:
who will listen when he prays?
What did his self-abasement profit him?

Notes

- a (34:3) That is, a dream is a mere reflection, as in a mirror.
- b (34:30) On the purification after contact with a corpse, see Num 19:11–22.

Chapter 35

1 One who keeps the law multiplies offerings;
2 one who pays heed to the commandments sacrifices a peace offering.
3 One who repays a favor offers fine flour,
4 and one who does almsgiving sacrifices a praise offering.
5 What is pleasing to the Lord is to turn away from wickedness,
and atonement is to turn away from injustice.
6 Do not appear in the Lord's presence empty-handed,[a]
7 for all these things are for the commandment's sake.
8 The offering of a righteous man makes the altar rich,
and its sweet smell is before the Most High.
9 The sacrifice of a righteous man is acceptable,
and the memorial portion of it will not be forgotten.
10 With a good eye give the Lord glory,
and do not make small the first fruits of your hands.
11 In every gift let your face shine,
and in gladness make your tithe holy.
12 Give to the Most High as he has given,
with a good eye, as your hand has found.
13 For the Lord is one who repays,
and he will repay you sevenfold.
14 Do not try to bribe him, for he will not accept it,
15 and do not lean on an unrighteous sacrifice;
for the Lord is judge,
and with him there is no favor to persons.
16 He will not take a person's part against a poor man,
and he will hear the prayer of one who has been wronged.

17 He will never overlook the orphan's supplication,
or the widow when she pours out her story.
18 Do not a widow's tears run down her cheek,
19 and her outcry rise against the one who made them fall?
20 One who serves with good will will be accepted,
and his petition will reach to the clouds.
21 The prayer of a humble man goes right through the clouds,
and until it draws near he will not be comforted;
he will not leave off until the Most High looks upon him
22 and gives judgment for the righteous and carries out judgment.
And the Lord will not be slow,
nor will he be patient with them,
until he has crushed the loins of the merciless
23 and paid back vengeance to the nations,
until he has taken away the crowd of the insolent
and broken to pieces the scepters of the unrighteous;
24 until he has paid back a man according to his doings,
and the works of human beings according to their designs;
25 until he has judged the cause of his people
and gladdened them with his mercy.
26 Mercy in the season of affliction is a lovely thing,
like clouds of rain in the season of drought.

Notes

- a (35:6) Exod 23:15; Deut 16:16.

Chapter 36

A Prayer for Israel

1 Have mercy on us, Master, God of all things, and look on us,
2 and cast the fear of you on all the nations.
3 Raise your hand against foreign nations,
and let them witness your power.
4 As in their sight you were shown holy in us,
so in our sight be shown great in them;
5 and let them know you, just as we too have known
that there is no God but you, Lord.

6 Make signs new and wonders different;
7 glorify your hand and your right arm.
8 Rouse your fury and pour out your wrath;
9 take away the adversary and wipe out the enemy.
10 Hurry on the season and remember the oath,
and let them tell out your mighty works.
11 Let the one who escapes be eaten up in the wrath of fire,
and those who mistreat your people find destruction.
12 Crush the heads of the enemy's rulers,
who declare, "No one is above us."
13 Gather all the tribes of Jacob,[a]
14 [Not used in this numbering; see the note at verse 13.]
15 [Not used in this numbering; see the note at verse 13.]
16 and give them their inheritance as from the beginning.
17 Have mercy, Lord, on a people called by your name,
and on Israel, whom you made like a firstborn.[b]
18 Have compassion on the city of your holiness,
Jerusalem, the place of your rest.
19 Fill Zion with the telling of your wonders,[c]
and your people with your glory.
20 Give testimony to those you created at the beginning,
and raise up the prophecies spoken in your name.
21 Pay their wages to those who wait on you,
and let your prophets prove to be faithful.
22 Listen, Lord, to the prayer of those who plead with you,
in keeping with Aaron's blessing for your people,[d]
so that everyone on earth may know
that you are the Lord, the eternal God.
23 The belly will eat any food,
yet one food is better than another.
24 As the throat tries out kinds of venison,
so a discerning heart tries out false words.
25 A twisted heart will bring grief,
and a man of experience will pay him back.

26 A woman will receive any male,
yet one daughter is better than another.
27 A wife's beauty brightens the face
and outdoes every desire of a man.
28 If on her tongue there is mercy and gentleness,
her husband is not like other sons of men.
29 One who acquires a wife makes a start on possessions,
a help fitting for him and a pillar of rest.[e]
30 Where no hedge is, the property is pillaged,
and a man without a wife roams about and groans.
31 For who will trust a nimble robber
darting from city to city?
So too a man who has no nest
and lodges wherever evening overtakes him.

Notes

- a (36:13) The numbering here follows NRSV, which has no verses 14–15 in this chapter (they are kept below as empty placeholders so that the following verse numbers match NRSV); KJV and other editions number this prayer 36:1–17. In the Greek manuscripts the transposed section (see the notes at 30:25 and 33:13) ends after verse 13, and the next words resume after the displaced block.
- b (36:17) Exod 4:22.
- c (36:19) The Greek is uncertain; some witnesses read "Fill Zion with your praise."
- d (36:22) Num 6:22–27.
- e (36:29) Gen 2:18, 20.

Chapter 37

1 Every friend will say, "I too am your friend";
but there is a friend who is a friend in name only.
2 Is it not a deadly grief
when a companion and friend becomes an enemy?
3 O wicked imagining, from where did you roll in
to cover the dry land with treachery?
4 A companion takes pleasure in a friend's good cheer,
but in a season of affliction he will be against him.
5 A companion toils alongside a friend for the belly's sake,
and in the face of battle he will take up the shield.

6 Do not forget a friend in your soul,
and do not be unmindful of him among your riches.
7 Every counselor praises counsel,
but there is one who counsels toward himself.
8 Keep your soul guarded from a counselor,
and know beforehand what his need is —
for he will counsel for himself —
so that he does not cast a lot over you
9 and say to you, "Your road is good,"
and then stand at a distance to see what happens to you.
10 Do not take counsel with one who eyes you with suspicion,
and hide your counsel from those who envy you.
11 Do not ask a woman for advice about her rival,
or a coward for counsel on war,
or a merchant about trade, or a buyer about a sale,
or an envious man about thankfulness,
or a cruel man about kindness,
or a lazy man about any kind of work,
or a seasonal worker about finishing the year's job,
or an idle servant about a heavy workload —
give no heed to any of these in a matter of counsel.
12 Instead, keep company at all times with a godly man
who, you know, keeps the commandments,
whose heart matches your own,
and who will feel your pain if you fall.
13 And make the counsel of your heart stand firm,
for nothing is more trustworthy to you than it.
14 For a man's soul sometimes brings him word
better than seven lookouts sitting on high on a watchtower.
15 And with all these, make your prayer to the Most High
that he may make your way straight in truth.
16 The beginning of every work is reason,
and before every action is counsel.
17 As the track of the heart's turning,

18 four portions spring up:
good and evil, life and death,
and the tongue is master over them always.
19 There is a man who is clever, the teacher of many,
and yet to his own soul he is of no use.
20 There is a clever speaker who is hated;
he will end up stripped of every food,
21 for grace was not given him from the Lord,
because he is stripped of all wisdom.
22 There is one who is wise for his own soul,
and the fruits of his understanding are trustworthy on his lips.
23 A wise man will teach his own people,
and the fruits of his understanding are trustworthy.
24 A wise man will be filled with blessing,
and all who see him will call him blessed.
25 The life of a man is days that can be numbered,
but the days of Israel are past numbering.
26 The wise man will inherit trust among his people,
and his name will live to the age.
27 Child, in your life put your soul to the test,
and see what is evil for it, and do not give it that.
28 For not everything is profitable for everyone,
and not every soul takes pleasure in everything.
29 Do not be insatiable for every delicacy,
and do not pour yourself out over foods;
30 for with much food there will be sickness,
and excess will come near to colic.
31 Through excess many have died,
but the one who takes heed will add to his life.

Chapter 38

1 Give the physician the honors owed him, against the times you need him,
for the Lord created him too.

2 For healing comes from the Most High,
and from the king he will receive a gift.
3 The physician's knowledge will lift up his head,
and in the sight of great men he will be admired.
4 The Lord created remedies out of the earth,
and a man of good sense will not spurn them.
5 Was not water made sweet by a piece of wood,[a]
so that his strength might be known?
6 And he gave human beings knowledge,
so that he might be glorified in his marvels.
7 By them he heals and takes away pain;
8 the perfumer makes a compound out of them.
His works will never be brought to an end,
and from him well-being is over the face of the earth.
9 Child, in your sickness do not be careless,
but pray to the Lord, and he will heal you.
10 Put away going astray and set your hands straight,
and cleanse your heart of every sin.
11 Give a sweet-smelling offering and a memorial portion of fine flour,[b]
and make your offering rich, as one who will soon be no more.
12 After that make room for the healer — the Lord made him as well —
and let him not go off from you, since you have need of him.
13 There is a season when success lies in their hands;
14 for they too will pray to the Lord
that he may prosper them in giving relief
and in healing, for the sake of preserving life.
15 One who sins in the sight of his Maker —
let him fall into the physician's hands.[c]
16 Child, let your tears flow over the dead,
and like one suffering terribly, start the lament;
shroud his body as is his due,
and do not neglect his burial.
17 Make the weeping bitter and the beating of the breast hot,
and keep up the mourning as he deserves,

a day or two, to avoid talk,
and then take comfort on account of grief.
18 For from grief comes death,
and grief of heart bends one's strength.
19 In misfortune grief also stays,
and the life of the poor man is a curse to the heart.[d]
20 Do not hand your heart over to grief;
send it away, remembering the end.
21 Do not forget, for there is no coming back;
you will not benefit him, and you will harm yourself.
22 Remember my sentence, for yours will be the same:
"For me yesterday, and for you today."
23 When the dead man is at rest, let his memory rest,
and take comfort over him when his spirit goes out.
24 The wisdom of a scribe comes in the opportunity of leisure,
and one who has little business will become wise.
25 How will he become wise who grips the plow
and whose boast is in the shaft of a goad,
who drives oxen and is taken up with their tasks,
and whose talk is about the offspring of bulls?
26 He gives his heart to turning furrows,
and his wakefulness to fodder for heifers.
27 So it is with every craftsman and master builder
who passes the night as he does the day;
those who cut the engravings of seals,
whose patience is in varying the pattern;
he will give his heart to making the likeness exact,
and his wakefulness to finishing the work.
28 So the smith, sitting beside the anvil
and studying the iron he works;
the breath of the fire will melt his flesh,
and in the heat of the furnace he wrestles;
the noise of the hammer deafens his ear,[e]
and his eyes are on the pattern of the vessel;

he will give his heart to finishing his works,
and his wakefulness to adorning them to completion.
29 So the potter, sitting at his work
and spinning the wheel with his feet,
who is always set down in anxious care over his work,
and all his output is by count;
30 with his arm he will shape the clay,
and before his feet he will bend its stiffness;
he will give his heart to completing the glaze,
and his wakefulness to cleaning out the kiln.
31 All these put their trust in their hands,
and each one is wise in his own work.
32 Without them no city will be lived in,
and people will not sojourn or walk about there.
33 Yet they will not be sought out for the council of the people,
and in the assembly they will not rise high;
they will not sit on the judge's seat,
and they will not understand the covenant of judgment;
34 they will not bring discipline and judgment to light,
and among the parables they will not be found.
Yet they keep the fabric of the age firm,
and their prayer is in the work of their craft.
How different the one who gives his soul
and ponders the law of the Most High!

Notes

- a (38:5) Exod 15:23–25.
- b (38:11) Lev 2:1–2. The last phrase is obscure in the Greek.
- c (38:15) The Hebrew, as reported, reads "will behave proudly before the physician."
- d (38:19) The Greek of this verse is obscure.
- e (38:28) Literally "renews his ear"; the Greek is uncertain.

Chapter 39

1 He will seek out the wisdom of all the ancients
and be taken up with prophecies;
2 he will keep the narratives of men of renown
and will go into the twists of parables;

3 he will seek out the hidden things of proverbs
and will busy himself with the riddles of parables.
4 He will serve in the midst of great men
and appear before a ruler;
he will travel through the land of foreign nations,
for he has put good and evil among human beings to the test.
5 He will give his heart to rising early
to the Lord who made him,
and before the Most High he will make his petition;
he will open his mouth in prayer
and make supplication about his sins.
6 If the great Lord so wills,
he will be filled with a spirit of understanding;
he will pour out sayings of his wisdom like rain
and in prayer give thanks to the Lord.
7 He will set straight his counsel and knowledge
and ponder the Lord's hidden things.
8 He will bring to light the discipline of his teaching
and will boast in the law of the Lord's covenant.
9 Many will praise his understanding,
and to the age it will not be wiped out;
his memory will not depart,
and his name will live from generation to generation.
10 His wisdom the nations will recount,
and his praise the congregation will announce.
11 If he lives on, his name will be greater than a thousand,
and if he rests in death, that is enough for him.
12 Still more I will tell, having thought it through,
for I am filled up like the moon at the full.
13 Listen to me, holy children, and bud
like a rose growing beside a stream in the field;
14 like frankincense give off a sweet smell,
and blossom like a lily;
spread your fragrance and sing a song of praise;
bless the Lord for all his works.

15 Give his name majesty
and acknowledge him with his praise,
with songs of the lips and with harps,
and say this in your acknowledgment:
16 "The works of the Lord are all very good,
and every command of his will happen in its season.
17 No one may say, 'What is this? Why is this?'
for all things will be sought out in their season.
At his word the water stood like a heap,[a]
and at the utterance of his mouth, the reservoirs of waters.
18 At his command all his good pleasure is done,
and there is no one who will lessen his saving work.
19 The works of all flesh are before him,
and nothing can be hidden from his eyes.
20 From age to age he looks on,
and nothing is a marvel before him.
21 No one may say, 'What is this? Why is this?'
for all things have been created for their uses.
22 His blessing has covered the dry land like a river
and soaked it like a flood.
23 Even so the nations will inherit his wrath,
as he turned waters into salt.[b]
24 His ways are level for the holy;
even so they are stumbling blocks for the lawless.
25 Good things were created for the good from the beginning,
even so evil things for sinners.
26 The most basic needs of human life
are water, fire, iron, and salt,
wheat flour of the finest quality, milk, and honey,
the juice of the grape, oil, and clothing.
27 All these are for good to the godly;[c]
even so for sinners they will be turned to evil.
28 Some winds were created for punishment;
in their anger they have strengthened their lashes.

At the end of time they will unleash their force
and quiet the anger of the one who made them.
29 Fire and hail and famine and death,
all these have been created for vengeance;
30 the teeth of wild beasts, and scorpions and vipers,
and a sword avenging the ungodly to their destruction.
31 They will be glad at his command,
and they will be made ready on earth for their uses,
and in their seasons they will not go beyond his word."
32 So from the beginning I was made firm,
and I thought it over and left it in writing:
33 "Good, every one, are the Lord's doings,
and each need in its hour he will furnish.
34 And no one may say, 'This is worse than that,'
for all things will prove worthy in their season."
35 And now with all your heart and mouth sing a song of praise
and bless the name of the Lord.

Notes

- a (39:17) Exod 15:8; Ps 33:7.
- b (39:23) Perhaps an allusion to the Dead Sea and the overthrow of Sodom (Gen 19).
- c (39:27) The Masada Hebrew scroll (MasSir), copied in the first century BC, preserves portions of the text from 39:27 to 44:17, as reported. It agrees closely with Cairo Geniza manuscript B, showing that the medieval Hebrew manuscripts largely preserve the ancient Hebrew text.

Chapter 40

1 Great preoccupation has been created for every human being,
and a heavy yoke is on the sons of Adam,
from the day of their coming out of their mother's womb
until the day of their return to the mother of all.[a]
2 Their reasonings and the fear of their heart:
the thought of what they wait for, the day of their end.
3 From the one who sits upon a throne in glory
to the one brought low in earth and ashes,
4 from the man who wears purple and a crown
down to the one dressed in coarse linen —

5 there is rage and jealousy and turmoil and unsteadiness
and fear of death and wrath and strife;
and in the season of rest upon the bed
night's sleep alters his knowledge.
6 A little, as good as nothing, he spends in rest,
and after that, in sleep, as by day on watch,
he is thrown into turmoil by the vision of his heart,
like one who has escaped from the face of battle.
7 In the moment of his need he wakes
and marvels that his fear was nothing.
8 With all flesh, from human being to beast,
and upon sinners sevenfold more,
9 come death and blood and strife and sword,
calamities, famine and crushing and the scourge.
10 For the lawless all these were created,
and on their account the flood came.
11 Whatever is out of the ground goes back to the ground,
and what is out of the waters goes back into the sea.
12 Every gift that bribes, every wrong, will be blotted out,
while faithfulness stands through the age.
13 The goods of the unrighteous will dry up like a river
and will die away like a great thunderclap in a rain.
14 When he opens his hands, he will be glad;[b]
even so transgressors will come to utter failure.
15 The offspring of the ungodly will not multiply branches,
and unclean roots are on the face of sheer rock.
16 The sedge on every water and riverbank
will be pulled up before any grass.
17 Kindness is like a garden in blessings,
and almsgiving stays to the age.
18 The life of one who is self-sufficient and of one who works will be made sweet,
but above them both is one who finds a treasure.

19 Children and the building of a city make a name firm,
but above them both a blameless wife is counted.
20 Wine and music gladden the heart,
but above them both is the love of wisdom.
21 Flute and harp make melody sweet,
but above them both is a pleasant tongue.
22 Grace and beauty the eye will long for,
but above them both, the green of a sown field.
23 Friend and companion meet in season,
but above them both, a wife with her husband.
24 Brothers and help are for a time of affliction,
but above them both, almsgiving will rescue.
25 Gold and silver will set the foot firm,
but above them both counsel is prized.
26 Money and strength will lift up the heart,
but above them both is the fear of the Lord.
In the fear of the Lord there is no lack,
and there is no need to seek help with it.
27 The fear of the Lord is like a blessed garden,
and it shelters a person better than any glory.
28 Child, do not live as a beggar;
it is better to die than to beg.
29 A man who looks to someone else's table —
his life is not to be counted as life;
he will defile his soul with someone else's foods,
but a man of understanding and discipline will be on his guard.
30 In the mouth of the shameless, begging will be sweet,
but in his belly a fire will burn.

Notes

- a (40:1) That is, the earth (compare Gen 3:19).
- b (40:14) The Greek of this line is obscure.

Chapter 41

1 O death, how bitter is the remembrance of you
to a man living at peace among his possessions,

to a man who has no distractions and prospers in everything
and still has strength to take food!
2 O death, your sentence is good
to a man in need and failing in strength,
in extreme old age and distracted about everything,
who is contrary and has lost patience!
3 Do not dread the sentence of death;
remember those who went before you and those who come after.
4 This is the sentence from the Lord for all flesh,
and why do you refuse the good pleasure of the Most High?
Whether ten or a hundred or a thousand years,
there is no reproach about life in Hades.
5 Abominable children become the children of sinners,
and they frequent the dwellings of the ungodly.
6 The inheritance of sinners' children will perish,
and with their offspring reproach will continue.
7 Children will lay the blame on an ungodly father,
for on his account they are reproached.
8 Woe to you, ungodly men,
who have forsaken the law of God Most High!
9 If you are born, you will be born for a curse,
and if you die, a curse will be your portion.[a]
10 All things that are from the earth will return to the earth;
so the ungodly go from curse to destruction.
11 People mourn over their bodies,
but the name of sinners, which is not good, will be wiped out.
12 Take thought for your name, for it will stay with you
longer than a thousand great treasures of gold.
13 A good life has a number of days,
but a good name stays to the age.
14 Keep discipline in peace, children.
Wisdom hidden away and treasure out of sight —
what profit is there in either?

15 Better a man who hides his folly
than a man who hides his wisdom.
16 Therefore feel shame as my word directs,
for it is not good to keep every kind of shame,
and not everything is approved by all in good faith.
17 Be ashamed before father and mother of fornication,
and before a ruler and a mighty man of a lie;
18 before a judge and a ruler of an offense,
before the assembly and the people of lawlessness;
19 before a partner and a friend of injustice,
and before the place where you sojourn of theft,
and before the truth of God and the covenant;
and of leaning your elbow on the bread,[b]
20 of contempt in taking and giving;
before those who greet you, of silence;
of gazing at a prostitute;
21 of turning away the face of your kinsman,
of taking away a portion and a gift;
of staring at a married woman;
22 of meddling with his servant girl —
do not stand over her bed;
before friends, of words of reproach —
after you have given, do not reproach.

Notes

- a (41:9) The Greek of this verse is uncertain; the Hebrew, as reported, differs.
- b (41:19) That is, bad manners at table; the Hebrew, as reported, differs.

Chapter 42

1 Be ashamed of repeating a word you have heard
and of laying bare secret words;
and you will be truly modest
and find favor in the sight of every person.
Of these things do not be ashamed,
and do not show partiality and so sin:

2 of the law of the Most High and the covenant,
and of judgment that acquits the ungodly;[a]
3 of reckoning with a partner and with fellow travelers,
and of giving a share of the inheritance of companions;
4 of strictness with balance and with weight stones,
of getting much or getting little;
5 of profit from selling to merchants,
of much discipline of children,
and of making the side of a wicked household slave bleed.
6 Over a wicked wife a seal is good,
and where there are many hands, lock things up.
7 Whatever you hand over, let it be by count and weight,
and put all giving and receiving in writing.
8 Do not be ashamed of disciplining the senseless and the fool,
or the very old man contending with the young;
and you will be truly well schooled
and approved in the sight of all the living.
9 A daughter is a hidden wakefulness for a father,
and worry over her drives away sleep:
in her youth, lest she pass her prime,
and when she has married, lest she be hated;
10 in her virginity, lest she be defiled
and become pregnant in her father's house;
when she has a husband, lest she transgress,
and when she is married, lest she be barren.
11 Over a headstrong daughter keep a firm guard,
so that she does not make you a laughingstock to your enemies,
a byword in the city and the talk of the people,
and shame you before the crowd.[b]
12 Do not look at anyone for beauty,
and do not sit in the midst of women;
13 for from clothing comes the moth,
and from a woman a woman's wickedness.
14 Better a man's wickedness than a woman who does good;
and a woman brings shame to the point of reproach.[c]

The Works of God in Creation

15 Now I will recall the works of the Lord
and tell what I have seen.
The Lord's words brought his works into being.[d]
16 The sun that gives light looks down on all things,
and the Lord's work is full of his glory.
17 The Lord has not given his holy ones power
to tell out all his marvels,
which the Lord Almighty has made firm
so that the whole might stand fast in his glory.
18 He tracked out the abyss and the heart,
and he saw through their cunning devices;
for the Most High knows all knowledge
and looks into the sign of the age,
19 declaring what has passed and what will be,
and uncovering the tracks of hidden things.
20 No thought slips past him;
not one word is hidden from him.
21 He has set in order the majestic works of his wisdom,
he who is before the age and to the age;
nothing has been added and nothing taken away,
and he had no need of any counselor.
22 How desirable are all his works,
down to a spark, to look upon!
23 All these live and stay to the age,
for all their uses, and all obey him.
24 All things are in pairs, one opposite the other,
and he has made nothing that falls short.
25 One thing confirms the good of another,
and who will have enough of gazing on his glory?

Notes

- a (42:2) The sense is "of giving just judgment, even if it acquits an ungodly man."
- b (42:11) The Hebrew, as reported, adds lines about her room having no lattice window or view of the entrance.

- c (42:14) This harsh saying is variously rendered; the Hebrew text, as reported, is partly damaged here.
- d (42:15) The Hebrew, as reported, adds "and his favor carried out his decree."

Chapter 43

1 The pride of the heights is the firmament in its clearness,
the look of heaven in a sight of glory.
2 The sun, when it appears, makes proclamation as it goes out:
a marvelous vessel, the work of the Most High.
3 At its noon it dries up the land,
and before its burning heat who will stand?
4 A man blowing a furnace works in burning heat;
three times as much the sun scorches mountains;
breathing out fiery vapors
and flashing out its rays, it dims the eyes.
5 Great is the Lord who made it,
and at his words it speeds on its course.
6 And the moon too, in all things in its season,
is a proclaiming of times and a sign of the age.
7 From the moon comes the sign of a feast day,
a light that wanes when it is complete.
8 The month is named after it,[a]
growing marvelously in its changing,
a vessel of the hosts on high,
shining out in the firmament of heaven.
9 The beauty of heaven is the glory of the stars,
an ornament giving light in the heights of the Lord.
10 At the words of the Holy One they stand in their ordered place,
and they will not grow slack in their watches.
11 Look at the rainbow and bless the One who made it;
it is very beautiful in its brightness.
12 It circles the heaven with a ring of glory;
the hands of the Most High have stretched it out.
13 By his command he makes the snow come swiftly
and speeds the lightnings of his judgment.

14 Because of this the storehouses are opened,
and clouds fly out like birds.
15 In his majesty he made clouds strong,
and hailstones are broken off.[b]
16 At his appearing, mountains will be shaken;
by his will the south wind will blow.
17 The voice of his thunder rebukes the earth,
and so does the storm from the north and the whirlwind.
Like birds settling, he sprinkles the snow,
and its coming down is like locusts alighting.
18 The eye marvels at the beauty of its whiteness,
and the heart is amazed at its falling.
19 Hoarfrost he scatters over the earth as if it were salt,
and as it hardens it grows into thorn-tips.
20 A chill wind blows from the north,
and crystal ice hardens over the water;
upon every pooling of water it comes to rest,
and the water dons it as a breastplate.
21 It will eat up the mountains and burn the wilderness
and quench green growth like fire.
22 A healing for all things is a mist coming swiftly;
dew, meeting the burning heat, will bring cheer.
23 By his reasoning he calmed the abyss
and planted islands in it.
24 Those who sail the sea tell of its danger,
and when we hear it with our ears we marvel.
25 In it are strange and marvelous works,
variety of every living thing,
the creation of sea monsters.
26 Because of him his messenger has success,[c]
and by his word all things hold together.
27 Many things we might say and not reach the end,
and the sum of our words is: "He is the All."[d]

28 Where shall we find strength to glorify him?
For he is the Great One above all his works.
29 The Lord is to be feared and is exceedingly great,
and marvelous is his dominion.
30 When you glorify the Lord, lift him up as far as you can,
for he will surpass even that;
and when you lift him up, gather your strength;
do not grow weary, for you will never reach the end.
31 Who has seen him and will describe him?
And who will make him great as he is?
32 Many hidden things are greater than these,
for we have seen few of his works.
33 For the Lord made all things,
and to the godly he gave wisdom.

Notes

- a (43:8) In Hebrew, "month" (chodesh) and "renew" (chiddesh) are related words; the Greek mēn (month) and mēnē (moon) keep a similar play.
- b (43:15) In verses 15–17 the order of lines differs between Hebrew and Greek, and modern versions rearrange them following the Hebrew; the Greek order is kept here.
- c (43:26) Or "his journey reaches its end"; the Greek is uncertain.
- d (43:27) Greek to pan. The Hebrew, as reported, reads "He is everything" (hu' hakkol).

Chapter 44

Hymn of the Fathers

1 Let us now praise men of glory,[a]
our fathers in their generations.
2 Great glory the Lord created in them,
his majesty from the age.
3 There were those who held lordship in their kingdoms
and men named for their might,
giving counsel by their understanding,
announcing things in prophecies;

4 leaders of the people by their counsels
and by their understanding of the people's learning,
wise in the words of their instruction;
5 those who sought out tunes of music
and set out poems in writing;
6 rich men, furnished with strength,
living in peace in their dwellings —
7 all these were glorified in their generations
and were a boast in their days.
8 There are some of them who have left a name behind them,
so that their praises are told.
9 Others there are of whom no memorial exists;
they are gone as if they never were,
they became like ones never born,
and so did their children after them.
10 But these were men of mercy,
whose righteous deeds have not been forgotten;
11 with their offspring a good inheritance will remain,
their descendants within the covenants.
12 Their offspring stand within the covenants,
and their children likewise, for their sake.
13 To the age their offspring will remain,
and their glory will not be wiped out.
14 Their bodies were buried in peace,
and their name lives to generations.
15 Peoples will tell out their wisdom,
and the assembly proclaims their praise.
16 Enoch pleased the Lord and was taken across,[b]
an example of repentance to generations.
17 Noah was found perfect, righteous;
in the season of wrath he became a replacement;[c]
on his account a remnant was left on the earth
when the flood came.

18 Covenants of the age were set with him,
that all flesh should not again be wiped out by a flood.
19 Great father of a throng of nations was Abraham;
none has turned up to equal him in glory;
20 The law of the Most High he kept,
and he entered into a covenant with God;
he marked the covenant in his own flesh,
and when he was put to the test, he proved faithful.[d]
21 For this he made it firm to him by oath
that in his seed nations should be blessed,
that he would make him many as earth's dust
and raise his seed on high as the stars are,
and make them heirs from sea to sea,
from the River to the ends of the land.
22 With Isaac too he set it so,
for the sake of Abraham his father.
23 He made the blessing for all peoples and the covenant
rest upon the head of Jacob;
he confirmed him with blessings
and gave him the land as his inheritance;
he set out its portions
and divided them among the twelve tribes.
From Jacob he brought forth a man of mercy,
who won the favor of everyone,

Notes

- a (44:1) So the heading in the Greek manuscripts (Paterōn hymnos); in the Hebrew, as reported, "Praise of the Fathers of Old." The hymn runs through chapter 50.
- b (44:16) Gen 5:24. The Hebrew of Geniza MS B, as reported, reads "a sign of knowledge"; the Masada scroll, as reported, lacks this verse.
- c (44:17) Gen 6:9. The Masada scroll's text breaks off at about this point, as reported.
- d (44:20) Gen 17:10–14; 22:1–18.

Chapter 45

1 beloved by God and by human beings,
Moses, whose memorial is in blessings.

2 He made him like the holy ones in glory[a]
and made him great in the terrors he brought on his enemies.
3 At his word he brought the signs to an end;[b]
he made him glorious before kings;
he gave him commands for his people
and showed him some of his glory.
4 In his faithfulness and meekness he made him holy;[c]
he chose him out of all flesh.
5 He let him hear his voice,
brought him into the thick darkness,
and face to face gave him the commandments,
the law of life and knowledge,
so that he could teach the covenant to Jacob
and his decrees to Israel.
6 He lifted up Aaron, a holy man like him,
his brother, of the tribe of Levi.
7 He set up an everlasting covenant for him
and gave him the priesthood of the people;
he blessed him with comeliness
and girded him with a robe of glory.
8 He clothed him in the perfection of boasting
and strengthened him with the vestments of might:
the linen undergarments, the long robe, and the ephod.[d]
9 And he surrounded him with pomegranates,
with very many golden bells all around,
to give out a sound as he walked,
to make a sound heard in the temple
as a memorial for the sons of his people;
10 with a holy robe of gold and blue and purple,
an embroiderer's handiwork;
with the oracle of judgment, the signs of truth,[e]
11 with twisted scarlet thread, a craftsman's work;
with precious stones cut like seals,
mounted in gold, a jeweler's work,

as a reminder, engraved in writing,
according to the number of Israel's tribes;
12 with a crown of gold upon the turban,
an engraving of a seal of holiness,[f]
a boast of honor, a work of might,
the desires of the eyes, richly adorned.
13 Before him there were never such lovely things;
to the age no outsider has put them on,
but only his sons
and his descendants perpetually.
14 His sacrifices shall be wholly burned,
twice every day continually.[g]
15 Moses filled his hands[h]
and anointed him with holy oil;
it became for him an everlasting covenant,
and for his offspring in the days of heaven,
to minister to the Lord and also to act as priest
and to bless his people in his name.
16 He chose him out of all the living
to bring an offering to the Lord,
incense and a sweet smell as a memorial portion,
to make atonement for your people.
17 He gave him, in his commandments,
authority in covenants of judgments,
to teach Jacob the testimonies
and to give light to Israel in his law.
18 Outsiders conspired against him
and envied him in the wilderness,
the men around Dathan and Abiram
and the band of Korah, in fury and wrath.[i]
19 The Lord saw it and was not pleased,
and they were brought to an end in the fury of his wrath;
he worked wonders against them,
to consume them in the flame of his fire.

20 And he added glory to Aaron
and gave him an inheritance;
he apportioned to him the first fruits of the firstborn;
bread first of all he prepared in abundance;
21 for they eat the sacrifices of the Lord,
which he gave to him and to his offspring.
22 Yet in the land of the people he will have no inheritance,
and there is no portion for him among the people;
for he himself is your portion and inheritance.[j]
23 Phinehas son of Eleazar is the third in glory,[k]
for his zeal in the fear of the Lord,
and for standing firm when the people turned away,
in the goodness of his soul's eagerness;
and he made atonement for Israel.
24 Therefore a covenant of peace was set up for him,
to be leader of the sanctuary and of his people,
that to him and to his offspring should belong
the greatness of the priesthood to the ages.
25 A covenant was also made with David,
the son of Jesse, from the tribe of Judah:
the king's inheritance goes from son to son only;
so Aaron's inheritance belongs to his descendants.[l]
26 May he give you wisdom in your heart
to judge his people in righteousness,
so that their good things may not vanish,
and their glory for their generations.

Notes

- a (45:2) "The holy ones" are the angels; the Hebrew, as reported, reads "like God" (Exod 7:1).
- b (45:3) Exod 8:12–13, 31; 33:18–23.
- c (45:4) Num 12:3, 7.
- d (45:8) Exod 28:4–43.
- e (45:10) That is, the Urim and Thummim (Exod 28:30), which the Greek renders "manifestations and truth."
- f (45:12) The plate inscribed "Holy to the Lord" (Exod 28:36).
- g (45:14) Lev 6:19–23; Exod 29:38–42.

- h (45:15) A Hebrew idiom for ordaining a priest (Lev 8).
- i (45:18) Num 16.
- j (45:22) Num 18:20. The Greek shifts to address Aaron directly.
- k (45:23) Num 25:1–13.
- l (45:25) The Greek of this verse is obscure; the Hebrew, as reported, differs and adds a call to "bless the Lord, the Good, who crowned you with glory."

Chapter 46

1 Mighty in war was Joshua[a] son of Nun,
the successor of Moses in prophecies,
who became, as his name means,
great for the saving of God's chosen,
to take vengeance on enemies who rose up,
so that he might give Israel its inheritance.
2 How glorified he was when he lifted his hands
and stretched out the sword against cities![b]
3 Who stood so firm before him?
For he waged the wars of the Lord.
4 Was it not by his hand that the sun stood back,
so that a single day was made two?[c]
5 He called on the Most High, the Mighty One,
when enemies pressed on him from every side,
and the great Lord heard him
with hailstones of overwhelming power.
6 He dashed down upon the nation in war,
and on the descent he destroyed those who stood against him,
so that the nations might know his full armor,
that his war was before the Lord;
for he followed after the Mighty One.
7 And in the days of Moses he did a deed of mercy,
he and Caleb son of Jephunneh:
they stood against the assembly,
held the people back from sin,
and stopped the murmuring of wickedness.[d]
8 Only these two were saved
out of six hundred thousand foot soldiers,

to be brought into their inheritance,
into a land flowing with milk and honey.
9 And the Lord gave Caleb strength,
and it stayed with him until old age,
so that he went up onto the heights of the land,
and his offspring held it as an inheritance,[e]
10 so that all the Israelites might see
that following the Lord is good.
11 The judges, each one named,
whose hearts never turned to prostitution
and who never abandoned the Lord —
may their memory be blessed!
12 May their bones sprout again from their place,
and may their name be renewed in the sons of those who were glorified.
13 Beloved by his Lord,
Samuel, the prophet of the Lord, established a kingdom
and anointed rulers over his people.
14 He judged the assembly by the Lord's law,
and the Lord kept watch over Jacob.
15 By his faithfulness he was proved an exact prophet,
and by his words he was known to be a trustworthy seer.
16 He called on the Lord, the Mighty One,
when enemies were pressing him on every side,
and he offered a nursing lamb.[f]
17 And the Lord thundered from heaven,
and with a great roar he made his voice heard;
18 and he wiped out the leaders of the Tyrians[g]
and all the rulers of the Philistines.
19 And before the time of his sleep of the age
he bore witness before the Lord and his anointed:
"Money, or even sandals, from any flesh I have not taken";
and no one accused him.[h]
20 And after his falling asleep he still prophesied;
he made known to the king his end

and raised his voice out of the ground in prophecy,
to blot out the people's lawlessness.[i]

Notes

- a (46:1) Greek Iēsous Nauē. The name Joshua (Yehoshua) means "the Lord saves."
- b (46:2) Josh 8:18–26.
- c (46:4) Josh 10:12–14.
- d (46:7) Num 14:6–10.
- e (46:9) Josh 14:6–15.
- f (46:16) 1 Sam 7:9–11.
- g (46:18) So the Greek; the Hebrew, as reported, reads "of the enemy" (the words for "Tyre" and "enemy" look alike in Hebrew).
- h (46:19) 1 Sam 12:3–5. "Sandals" follows the Greek and Hebrew (compare 1 Sam 12:3 in the Greek).
- i (46:20) 1 Sam 28:7–19.

Chapter 47

1 After him Nathan appeared
to prophesy in David's time.
2 As the fat is set apart from the peace offering,[a]
so David was set apart from the sons of Israel.
3 With lions he played as with young goats,
and with bears as with lambs of the flock.[b]
4 As a young man, did he not kill a giant
and remove the shame from his people,
when he raised his hand with a stone in the sling
and struck down Goliath's boasting?
5 For he called on the Lord Most High,
and he gave strength to his right hand
to remove a man mighty in war
and to raise up the horn of his people.
6 So they glorified him for his ten thousands[c]
and praised him in the blessings of the Lord,
when the crown of glory was brought to him.
7 For he wiped out his enemies all around
and brought to nothing the Philistines, his adversaries;
to this day he has crushed their horn.

8 In every work of his he gave thanks
to the Holy One, the Most High, with a word of glory;
with all his heart he sang songs of praise,
and he loved the One who made him.
9 He set singers before the altar,
to make sweet melodies by their voices.[d]
10 He gave the feasts their comeliness
and set the seasons in order to completion,
while they praised his holy name
and the sanctuary rang out from early morning.
11 The Lord put away his sins[e]
and exalted his horn to the age;
a covenant of kingship he granted him
and a throne of glory in Israel.
12 After him a wise son rose up,
who on his account lived in broad security.
13 Solomon reigned in days of peace,
and God gave him rest all around,
so that he might set up a house for his name
and prepare a sanctuary to the age.
14 How wise you were in your youth,
and you were filled with understanding like a river!
15 Your soul covered the earth,
and you filled it with parables of riddles.
16 To islands far away your name went out,
and for your peace you were beloved.
17 At your songs, your proverbs, your parables,
and your interpretations the lands were amazed.[f]
18 You gathered gold like tin
and heaped up silver like lead,
by the name of the Lord God,
the one called the God of Israel.
19 Yet you set your loins down beside women
and gave them dominion over your body.[g]

20 You put a blemish on your glory
and profaned your offspring,
bringing wrath upon your children;
and I was grieved over your folly,[h]
21 so that the sovereignty was split in two,
and out of Ephraim a disobedient kingdom ruled.
22 But the Lord will never abandon his mercy,
nor allow any of his words to fail;
he will not wipe out the descendants of his chosen one,
or destroy the offspring of the man who loved him.
He gave Jacob a remnant,
and David a root from his own family.
23 And Solomon went to rest with his fathers
and left behind him one of his offspring,
broad in folly and lacking understanding,
Rehoboam,[i] who turned the people away by his counsel.
And Jeroboam son of Nebat, who made Israel sin,
and gave Ephraim a way of sin —
24 and their sins multiplied exceedingly,
so as to remove them from their land.[j]
25 For they sought out every wickedness,
until vengeance came upon them.

Notes

- a (47:2) Lev 3:3–5.
- b (47:3) 1 Sam 17:34–37.
- c (47:6) 1 Sam 18:7.
- d (47:9) 1 Chr 16:4–6; 25:1–7. GII adds "and daily they sing his praises in their songs."
- e (47:11) 2 Sam 12:13; 7:12–16.
- f (47:17) 1 Kgs 4:29–34; 10:1–9.
- g (47:19) 1 Kgs 11:1–8.
- h (47:20) So some Greek witnesses; others read "and they were grieved."
- i (47:23) A pun in the Hebrew, as reported: Rehoboam, "the people is broad," is called "broad in folly" (rechab ʻivvelet). See 1 Kgs 12.
- j (47:24) 2 Kgs 17:6–23.

Chapter 48

1 Then a prophet arose like fire, Elijah,
whose word blazed like a lamp.[a]
2 He brought a famine upon them,
and by his zeal he made them few.
3 By the word of the Lord he shut up the heaven;
so too he brought down fire three times.[b]
4 How glorified you were, Elijah, in your wonders!
And who has a boast like yours?
5 A corpse you roused out of death,
out of Hades, at the word of the Most High;[c]
6 you brought kings down to destruction
and men held in glory from their beds;
7 you heard rebuke at Sinai
and judgments of vengeance at Horeb;[d]
8 you anointed kings for repayment
and prophets as successors after you;
9 you were taken up in a whirlwind of fire,
in a chariot with horses of fire;[e]
10 you are written down as ready for reproofs at the appointed times,
to calm wrath before it breaks into fury,
to turn the heart of the father to the son
and to restore the tribes of Jacob.[f]
11 Happy are those who saw you,
and those who were adorned with love,
for we also will surely live.[g]
12 Elijah was covered over by a whirlwind,
and Elisha was filled with his spirit;
in his days he was not shaken by any ruler,
and no one brought him under subjection.
13 No word was too hard for him,
and even when he had fallen asleep, his body prophesied.[h]
14 In his life he did wonders,
and in his death his works were marvelous.

15 Despite all this the people did not repent
or turn away from their sins,
until they were taken from their land as plunder
and scattered across the whole earth.
Very few people were left,
along with a ruler from David's house.
16 Some of them did what pleased God,
while others piled up sins.
17 Hezekiah fortified his city
and brought water into its midst;
he dug through sheer rock with iron
and built pools for water.[i]
18 In his days Sennacherib came up
and sent Rabshakeh, and set out;
he lifted up his hand against Zion
and boasted in his arrogance.[j]
19 Then their hearts and their hands shook,
and they writhed like women giving birth.
20 And they called on the Lord who is merciful,
spreading out their hands to him;
and the Holy One heard them quickly from heaven
and redeemed them by the hand of Isaiah.
21 He struck the camp of the Assyrians,
and his angel wiped them out.[k]
22 For Hezekiah did what was pleasing to the Lord
and held firmly to the ways of David his father,
which Isaiah the prophet commanded,
who was great and trustworthy in his vision.
23 In his days the sun went backward,
and he added life to the king.[l]
24 With a mighty spirit he looked on the last days
and gave comfort to the mourners of Zion.[m]
25 To the age he showed the things that were to be,
and the hidden things before they came.

Notes

- a (48:1) 1 Kgs 17–19; 2 Kgs 1–2.
- b (48:3) 1 Kgs 18:38; 2 Kgs 1:10, 12.
- c (48:5) 1 Kgs 17:17–24.
- d (48:7) 1 Kgs 19:8–18.
- e (48:9) 2 Kgs 2:11.
- f (48:10) Mal 4:5–6 (3:23–24 in Hebrew); Isa 49:6.
- g (48:11) The Greek of this verse is uncertain, and the Hebrew, as reported, is damaged here.
- h (48:13) 2 Kgs 13:20–21.
- i (48:17) 2 Kgs 20:20; 2 Chr 32:30. Hezekiah's tunnel in Jerusalem, about 1,750 feet (533 m) long, survives with its Siloam inscription.
- j (48:18) 2 Kgs 18:13–37; Isa 36.
- k (48:21) 2 Kgs 19:35.
- l (48:23) 2 Kgs 20:1–11; Isa 38.
- m (48:24) Isa 40:1; 61:2–3.

Chapter 49

1 The memory of Josiah is like a blending of incense
prepared by the work of a perfumer;
in every mouth it will be sweet as honey,
and like music at a banquet of wine.
2 He was set straight in the turning back of the people[a]
and took away the abominations of lawlessness.
3 He set his heart straight toward the Lord;
in the days of the lawless he made godliness strong.
4 Except for David and Hezekiah and Josiah,
all committed fault upon fault,
for they forsook the law of the Most High;
the kings of Judah came to an end.
5 For they gave their horn to others
and their glory to a foreign nation,
6 who set on fire the chosen city of the sanctuary
and made her streets desolate,
7 as foretold by the hand of Jeremiah; for they mistreated him,
and yet he had been made holy in the womb as a prophet,
to root up and to afflict and to destroy,
and likewise to build and to plant.[b]

8 Ezekiel saw the vision of glory,
which he showed him above the chariot of the cherubim.[c]
9 For he remembered the enemies in a rainstorm,[d]
and did good to those who made their ways straight.
10 And of the twelve prophets[e]
may the bones sprout again from their place,
for they comforted Jacob
and redeemed them in the faithfulness of hope.
11 How shall we make Zerubbabel great?
He too was like a signet ring on the right hand,[f]
12 and so was Joshua son of Jozadak;
in their days these built the house
and lifted up a temple holy to the Lord,
made ready for everlasting glory.[g]
13 Great too is the memory of Nehemiah,
who raised up our fallen walls for us
and set up gates and bars
and raised up our ruined houses.[h]
14 No one has been created on the earth like Enoch,
for he was taken up from the earth.[i]
15 Nor was a man born like Joseph,
leader of his brothers, a prop of his people,
and his bones were watched over.[j]
16 Shem and Seth were glorified among human beings,
and above every living thing in creation is Adam.

Notes

- a (49:2) 2 Kgs 22–23.
- b (49:7) Jer 1:5, 10; 20:1–2; 37–38.
- c (49:8) Ezek 1; 10.
- d (49:9) The Greek is obscure (compare Ezek 13:11–13; 38:22). The Hebrew, as reported, reads "he also mentioned Job" (Ezek 14:14, 20); the Hebrew words for "enemy" (ʿoyeb) and "Job" (ʿiyyob) look alike.
- e (49:10) The Twelve (Minor) Prophets, Hosea to Malachi, already counted as one collection.
- f (49:11) Hag 2:23.
- g (49:12) Ezra 3:2, 8–13; Hag 1:12–15. Greek Iēsous.

- h (49:13) Neh 2–7. Ezra is not named in the hymn.
- i (49:14) Gen 5:24; see 44:16.
- j (49:15) Gen 50:24–25; Exod 13:19; Josh 24:32.

Chapter 50

1 Simon son of Onias,[a] the high priest,
who in his life repaired the house
and in his days made the temple strong;
2 by him the foundation was laid for the double height,
the lofty retaining wall of the temple enclosure.
3 In his days a cistern for water was dug,
a reservoir like the sea in its circumference.
4 He took thought for his people against their fall
and made the city strong against siege.
5 How glorified he was in the turning of the people[b]
as he came out from the house of the veil!
6 Like the morning star in the midst of a cloud,
like the moon at the full in its days,
7 like the sun shining on the temple of the Most High,
and like the rainbow giving light amid clouds of glory,
8 like a bloom of roses in the days of new fruits,
like lilies at an outflow of water,
like a green shoot of Lebanon on summer days,
9 like fire and frankincense on the censer,
like a vessel of hammered gold
adorned with every precious stone,
10 like an olive putting out its fruit,
and like a cypress raised high among the clouds.
11 When he took up his robe of boasting
and put on the perfection of boasting,
in going up to the holy altar
he made the precinct of the sanctuary glorious.
12 And when he received the portions from the priests' hands
while he himself stood by the hearth of the altar,
around him was a garland of brothers,

like a young growth of cedars in Lebanon;
and they surrounded him like the trunks of palms,
13 all the sons of Aaron in their glory,
with the Lord's offering in their hands,
before the whole assembly of Israel.
14 Finishing the service at the altars
and setting in order the offering to the Most High, the Almighty,
15 He reached out his hand for the cup
and poured out a drink offering of grape juice;
at the base of the altar he emptied it out,
an aroma pleasing to the Most High, the King of all.
16 Then the sons of Aaron shouted out;
they sounded with trumpets of hammered metal;
they made a great sound heard
as a memorial before the Most High.
17 Then all the people together hurried
and fell on their faces on the ground
to worship their Lord,
the Almighty, God Most High.
18 And the singers gave praise with their voices;
in the great house they made sweet melody.[c]
19 And the people entreated the Lord Most High
with prayer in the presence of the Merciful One,
till the Lord's worship was fully ordered
and his service was brought to completion.
20 Then, coming down, he raised his hands
over all the assembly of Israel's sons,
to pronounce the Lord's blessing with his lips
and glory in his name;[d]
21 and again they bent low in worship,
to take the blessing from the Most High.
22 And now bless the God of all,
who does great things everywhere,
who raises us up from our mothers' wombs
and treats us with his mercy.

23 May he grant us joy of heart,
and may Israel have peace in our time,
as in the days of old.
24 May he entrust his mercy to us,
and in our days may he redeem us.[e]
25 With two nations my soul is vexed,
and the third is not a nation:
26 those who dwell on the mountain of Samaria,[f] and the Philistines,
and the foolish people that dwells in Shechem.
27 I have written in this book
teaching in wisdom and knowledge,
I, Jesus son of Sirach, Eleazar, of Jerusalem,[g]
who let wisdom pour out of his heart like rain.
28 Blessed is the one who occupies himself with these things,
and the one who lays them on his heart will become wise.
29 If he practices them, he will be strong in every situation,
for the Lord's light is his path.[h]

Notes

- a (50:1) Simon II, high priest about 219–196 BC; Ben Sira probably knew him. The Hebrew, as reported, reads "Simon son of Johanan."
- b (50:5) Probably the Day of Atonement (Lev 16), when the high priest came out from the holy of holies; some take it of the daily offering.
- c (50:18) So the Greek, as best it can be read; the line is obscure.
- d (50:20) The priestly blessing of Num 6:24–26, in which, according to later Jewish tradition (as reported), the high priest pronounced the divine name in the temple.
- e (50:24) The Hebrew, as reported, reads instead: "May his steadfast love abide with Simon, and may he keep for him the covenant of Phinehas," a prayer for the high-priestly line that the Greek translator, writing after that line had lost the office, made general.
- f (50:26) The Hebrew, as reported, reads "Seir" (Edom). The "foolish people" in Shechem are the Samaritans.
- g (50:27) The Greek manuscripts vary on the name; the Hebrew, as reported, reads "Simeon son of Jeshua son of Eleazar son of Sira."
- h (50:29) GII adds "and to the godly he has given wisdom. Blessed be the Lord to the age. So be it, so be it."

Chapter 51

A Prayer of Jesus son of Sirach

1 I will thank you, Lord, my King,
and praise you, God my Savior;
I will give thanks to your name,
2 for you became my shelter and my help,
and you redeemed my body from destruction
and from the snare of a slandering tongue,
from lips that work out a lie;
and in the face of those who stood by you became my helper,
3 and you redeemed me, by the abundance of your mercy and of your name,
from the bites of those ready to devour,
from the hand of those seeking my life,
from the many afflictions I had,
4 from choking fire on every side,
and from the midst of a fire I had not kindled,
5 from the depth of the belly of Hades,
from an unclean tongue and a lying word —
6 slander from a dishonest tongue before the king.
My soul came close to death,
and my life drew near to Hades below.
7 They surrounded me on every side, and there was no one to help;
I looked for the help of human beings, and there was none.
8 Then I remembered your mercy, Lord,
and the help you have given from ancient times,
how you deliver those who wait for you
and save them from their enemies' hands.
9 And I lifted up my supplication from the earth
and prayed for rescue from death.
10 I cried out to the Lord, the Father of my lord,[a]
not to abandon me in my days of distress,
in the age of the proud, when no help was to be found.
11 I will praise your name continually
and sing a song of praise in thanksgiving;
and my supplication was heard,

12 for you saved me from destruction
and rescued me from an evil time.
Therefore I will give thanks and praise you
and bless the name of the Lord.[b]

Ben Sira's Search for Wisdom

13 While I was still young, before I went wandering,
I sought wisdom openly in my prayer.[c]
14 Before the temple I asked for her,
and to the very end I will seek her out.
15 From her blossom, as from a ripening grape, my heart was glad in her;
my foot walked on the level path;
from my youth I followed her track.
16 I bent my ear a little and received her,
and I found much discipline for myself.
17 I made progress in her;
to the One who gives me wisdom I will give glory.
18 For I resolved to put her into practice,
and I was zealous for the good, and I will never be put to shame.
19 My soul wrestled with her,
and in my doing of the law I was exact;
I spread out my hands to the height
and mourned over my ignorance of her.
20 I set my soul straight toward her,
and I found her through purity.
From the beginning I gained understanding together with her;
therefore I will never be abandoned.
21 My insides were stirred to seek her;
therefore I have gained a good possession.
22 The Lord gave me a tongue as my reward,
and with it I will praise him.
23 Draw near to me, you who are unschooled,
and lodge in my house of instruction.[d]
24 Why do you say you lack these things,
and your souls are so very thirsty?

25 I opened my mouth and spoke:
Gain her for yourselves without money.
26 Put your neck under the yoke,
and let your soul receive discipline;
she is near at hand to be found.
27 See with your eyes that I toiled little
and found much rest for myself.
28 Get a share of discipline with a large sum of silver,
and you will gain much gold by her.
29 May your soul be glad in his mercy,
and may you never be put to shame in praising him.
30 Do your work before the appointed time,
and in his time he will give you your wage.[e]

Notes

- a (51:10) So the Greek; the Hebrew, as reported, reads "I exalted the Lord: 'You are my Father.'"
- b (51:12) After this verse Cairo Geniza MS B, as reported, has a litany of sixteen lines modeled on Ps 136 ("Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good, for his steadfast love is to the age"), including thanks to the one "who makes a horn sprout for the house of David" and "who chose the sons of Zadok to be priests." It is absent from the Greek and the Syriac.
- c (51:13) Verses 13–30 form an alphabetic acrostic in the Hebrew. The Qumran Psalms Scroll (11QPs-a, first century AD) preserves 51:13–20 and the end of verse 30, as reported, as a separate poem among the Psalms of David, in a form with bolder bridal imagery than the Greek or Geniza MS B; many scholars hold that MS B's text of these verses is partly a retranslation or reworking. The other Qumran Sirach manuscript, 2Q18 (2QSir), preserves fragments of chapter 6, not of this poem.
- d (51:23) The first known use of the expression, in Hebrew, as reported, beth midrash, the later name for a house of study.
- e (51:30) Some Greek manuscripts end with the subscription "Wisdom of Jesus son of Sirach."

Baruch

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 And these are the words of the book written in Babylon by Baruch,[a]
the son of Neraiah, Neraiah son of Mahseiah, Mahseiah son of
Zedekiah, Zedekiah son of Hasadiah, Hasadiah son of Hilkiah, 2 in
the fifth year, on the seventh day of the month,[b] when the Chaldeans
captured Jerusalem and set it ablaze. 3 And Baruch read out the words
of this book in the ears of Jeconiah son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah,[c]
and in the ears of all the people who came to the book, 4 and in the
ears of the men of power and of the king's sons, and in the ears
of the elders, and in the ears of all the people from the least to the
greatest, of all who lived in Babylon by the river Sud.[d] 5 And they
wept and fasted and prayed before the Lord; 6 and they collected
silver, each according to what his hand could give, 7 and this they
dispatched to Jerusalem, to Jehoiakim the priest,[e] whose father was
Hilkiah and whose grandfather was Shallum, and to the priests and
every one of the people present with him at Jerusalem, 8 at the time
when he received the vessels of the Lord's house, carried off out of
the temple, to bring them back to Judah's land, on the tenth of Sivan[f]
— vessels of silver made by Zedekiah son of Josiah, Judah's king, 9
after Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had carried off Jeconiah and
the rulers and the captives and the men of power and the people of
the land from Jerusalem, and brought them to Babylon.
10 And they said: See, we send you silver; with it purchase whole burnt
offerings, sin offerings, and incense; make ready a grain offering, and
present them on the altar of the Lord our God; 11 and pray for the life
of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and for the life of Belshazzar his
son,[g] that their days may be like the days of heaven above the earth. 12
And the Lord will give us strength and will give light to our eyes, and
we shall live under the shadow of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon

and under the shadow of Belshazzar his son, and we shall serve them many days and find favor before them. 13 And make prayer for us to the Lord our God, because against the Lord our God we have sinned, and to this day the Lord's fury and his anger have not turned from us. 14 And you shall read out this book that we have sent to you, to make confession in the house of the Lord on the day of the feast and on the days of the appointed season.

Confession of Sin 15 Then say: Righteousness belongs to the Lord our God,[h] while shame covers our faces, as it does today, every person of Judah and all who live in Jerusalem, 16 our kings as well, and our rulers, our priests, our prophets, and our fathers, 17 because we have sinned before the Lord 18 and disobeyed him, and we did not heed the voice of the Lord our God, to walk in the ordinances of the Lord that he set before our face. 19 From the day when the Lord brought our fathers out of the land of Egypt until this day we have been disobedient to the Lord our God, and we were careless in not heeding his voice. 20 And the evils have fastened on us, and the curse that the Lord ordained by Moses his servant on the day he led our fathers out of Egypt's land, to give us a land flowing with milk and honey, as it is this day.[i] 21 And we did not heed the voice of the Lord our God, in all the words of the prophets whom he sent to us; 22 but we went off each one in the intent of his own evil heart, to serve other gods and to do what is evil in the eyes of the Lord our God.

Notes

- a (1:1) Jeremiah's secretary (Jer 32:12; 36:4–32; 45:1). The Greek spells the names Nērias, Maasaias, Sedekias, Asadias and Chelkias.
- b (1:2) The month is not named. If counted from the fall of Jerusalem (587/586 BC), the fifth year is about 582 BC.
- c (1:3) Jeconiah (Jehoiachin) was taken to Babylon in 597 BC (2 Kgs 24:8–17; 25:27–30).
- d (1:4) The river Sud is otherwise unknown.
- e (1:7) Not the high priest of 2 Kgs 25:18 (Seraiah); this Jehoiakim is otherwise unknown.
- f (1:8) Sivan is the third month, May–June. Most take "he" as Baruch.
- g (1:11) Compare Jer 29:7. Belshazzar was in fact the son of Nabonidus (compare Dan 5:2).
- h (1:15) Verses 1:15–2:19 closely follow the prayer of Dan 9:4–19.

- i (1:20) Deut 28:15–68.

Chapter 2

1 So the Lord made good on the warning he had spoken against us,
against the judges who ruled Israel, against our kings and our leaders,
and against everyone in Israel and Judah, 2 to bring upon us great
evils, such as had not been done under the whole of heaven as he did
in Jerusalem, according to what is written in the law of Moses, 3 that
a man among us would eat his son's flesh, and another his daughter's
flesh.[a] 4 He put them under the power of all the kingdoms around
us, to become an object of scorn and ruin among all the surrounding
nations where the Lord had dispersed them. 5 And they were laid low
and not lifted up, because against the Lord our God we sinned, not
heeding his voice. 6 To the Lord our God belongs righteousness, but
to us and to our fathers shame of face, as it is this day. 7 All that the
Lord spoke against us, all these evils have come upon us. 8 Yet we
have not entreated the face of the Lord, that each might turn back
from the intents of his evil heart. 9 And the Lord kept watch over the
evils, and the Lord brought them upon us; for the Lord is righteous in
all his works that he commanded us. 10 And we did not heed his voice,
to walk in the ordinances of the Lord that he set before our face.

Prayer for Deliverance 11 And now, Lord God of Israel, who brought
your people out of the land of Egypt with a strong hand and with
signs and with wonders and with great power and with a lifted-up
arm, and made yourself a name, as it is this day: 12 we have sinned,
we have done impiety, we have done wrong, Lord our God, against
all your just decrees. 13 Let your fury turn away from us, for we are
left few among the nations where you scattered us. 14 Hear, Lord,
our prayer and our petition, and deliver us for your own sake, and
grant us favor in the eyes of those who led us away captive, 15 so
that the whole earth may know that you are the Lord our God, for
Israel and his race are called by your name. 16 Lord, look down from
your holy house and take thought for us; bend your ear, Lord, and
hear; 17 open your eyes, Lord, and look; it is not the dead in Hades,
whose life breath has left their bodies, who will give the Lord glory

and vindication;[b] 18 but the soul that is grieved beyond measure, that
goes about bowed and feeble, and the eyes that fail, and the soul that
hungers, will give you glory and justice, Lord. 19 For it is not on the
just deeds of our fathers and our kings that we lay down our plea for
mercy before your face, Lord our God.[c] 20 For you have sent your fury
and your wrath upon us, as you spoke by the hand of your servants
the prophets, saying: 21 This is what the Lord says: Bow your shoulders
to serve the king of Babylon, and you will stay on the soil I gave to
your ancestors.[d] 22 But if you do not heed the voice of the Lord to serve
the king of Babylon, 23 I will silence in the cities of Judah and in the
outskirts of Jerusalem the sound of mirth and the sound of gladness,
the bridegroom's sound and the bride's sound, and all the land will be
a waste with no one dwelling in it.[e] 24 But we did not obey your voice
by serving the king of Babylon; and you fulfilled the warnings you
gave through your servants the prophets, that our kings' bones and
our ancestors' bones would be dug up from where they lay.[f] 25 And see,
they lie cast out to the day's heat and the night's frost; and in cruel
pains they died, by famine and by sword and by pestilence.[g] 26 And
the house that bears your name you have reduced to what it is now,
because of the evil done by Israel's house and Judah's house. 27 Yet you
have dealt with us, Lord our God, according to all your gentleness
and according to all your great compassion, 28 just as you declared
through your servant Moses on the day you ordered him to write
your law in front of the Israelites: 29 If you will not heed my voice,
this great and teeming throng will surely be turned into a little band
among the nations where I will scatter them.[h] 30 For I know that they
will not heed me, because it is a stiff-necked people. But in the land
of their exile they will turn back to their heart,[i] 31 and they will know
that I am the Lord their God. And I will give them a heart and ears
that hear, 32 and in the land of their exile they shall praise me, and my
name they shall remember, 33 and they will turn back from their stiff
back and from their wicked deeds, for they will remember the way of
their fathers, who sinned before the Lord. 34 I will return them to the
land I promised with an oath to their forefathers, to Abraham, Isaac,
and Jacob, and they will be its masters; I will make them numerous,

and they will not dwindle. 35 And I will set up for them a covenant of the age, that I may be their God and they may be my people; and I will no longer remove my people Israel from the land that I have given them.[j]

Notes

- a (2:3) Lev 26:29; Deut 28:53; Lam 4:10.
- b (2:17) Ps 6:5; 115:17; Isa 38:18.
- c (2:19) Dan 9:18.
- d (2:21) Jer 27:11–12.
- e (2:23) Jer 7:34; 16:9; 25:10.
- f (2:24) Jer 8:1–2.
- g (2:25) Greek apostolē, "a sending," probably for Hebrew deber, "pestilence" (compare Jer 32:36).
- h (2:29) Deut 28:62–64.
- i (2:30) Deut 30:1–10.
- j (2:35) Jer 31:31–33; 32:40.

Chapter 3

1 Lord Almighty, God of Israel, a soul in anguish and a wearied spirit cries out to you. 2 Hear, Lord, and have mercy, for we have sinned before you. 3 For you sit enthroned to the age, and we are perishing to the age. 4 Lord Almighty, God of Israel, hear now the prayer of Israel's dead[a] and of the sons of those who sinned before you, who would not listen to the Lord their God's voice; and so the evils have fastened on us. 5 Do not remember the wrongdoings of our fathers, but remember your hand and your name at this time. 6 For you are the Lord our God, and we will praise you, Lord. 7 For this reason you have set the fear of you in our hearts, that we might call upon your name; and in our exile we shall praise you, since we have put away from our heart all the wrongdoing of our fathers who sinned before you. 8 Look, today we are in exile where you dispersed us, an object of scorn, a curse, and a punishment for everything our ancestors did wrong in turning away from the Lord our God.

In Praise of Wisdom

9 Hear, Israel, the commandments of life;[b]
give ear to know understanding.

10 Why, Israel, why is it that you are in your enemies' land,
grown old in a country not your own,
11 that you have been defiled together with the dead,
that you are counted among those in Hades?
12 You have forsaken the spring of wisdom.
13 If you had walked in the way of God,
you would be dwelling in peace to the age.
14 Find out where understanding is,
where power is, where insight is,
and so learn at once
where long life and survival are,
where to find light for the eyes, and peace.
15 Who has discovered where she dwells?
Who has gone in to her treasure-houses?
16 Where now are the nations' rulers,
and those who were lords over the earth's beasts,
17 those who made sport with the birds of heaven,
and those who heaped up silver and gold,
in which human beings trust,
and of whose getting there is no end?
18 For those who worked silver with such anxious care —
there is no finding out their works.[c]
19 They have disappeared and descended to Hades,
and others have taken their places.
20 Younger ones have seen the light
and have dwelt upon the earth;
but the way of knowledge they have not known,
21 nor grasped her paths,
nor taken hold of her;
their sons have wandered far from her road.
22 No news of her reached Canaan,
and she was never seen in Teman;[d]
23 nor the sons of Hagar, who seek understanding on the earth,
the traders of Merran[e] and Teman,

the tellers of tales and the seekers of understanding —
the way of wisdom they have not known,
nor have they remembered her paths.
24 O Israel, how great is the house of God,
and how vast the place of his possession![f]
25 It is great and has no end;
it is lofty and without measure.
26 There the giants were born, the renowned of old,[g]
great in stature, skilled in war.
27 Not these did God choose,
nor to these did he grant the way of knowledge;
28 and they perished because they had no insight;
they perished through their folly.
29 Who has climbed into heaven and seized her
and fetched her down from the clouds?[h]
30 Who has crossed over the sea and found her,
and will bring her back for choice gold?
31 There is no one who knows her way,
nor anyone who ponders her path.
32 But the One who knows all things knows her;
he found her out by his understanding.
The One who prepared the earth for time of the age
filled it with four-footed creatures;
33 the One who sends out the light, and it goes;
he called it, and it obeyed him with trembling.
34 The stars shone at their posts and rejoiced;
he summoned them, and they answered, “Here we are!”
They shone cheerfully for their Maker.
35 This is our God;
no other shall be reckoned beside him.
36 He found out the whole way of knowledge
and gave her to Jacob his servant
and to Israel, the one he loved.

37 After this she appeared on earth
and lived her life among human beings.[i]

Notes

- a (3:4) Greek "dead." Probably the Hebrew methe, "men of," was read as methe, "dead of"; NRSV renders "people."
- b (3:9) The poem of 3:9–4:4 draws on Job 28 and Deut 30:11–20, and, like Sir 24:23, identifies Wisdom with the Law (4:1).
- c (3:18) The Greek of this verse is obscure.
- d (3:22) Teman in Edom was famed for wisdom (Jer 49:7; Obad 8–9).
- e (3:23) Merran is unknown; perhaps Midian (compare Gen 37:28).
- f (3:24) The whole creation is meant.
- g (3:26) Gen 6:4.
- h (3:29) Deut 30:12–13; compare Rom 10:6–7.
- i (3:37) Compare Prov 8:31; Sir 24:8–12. Many Christian writers from the 2nd century AD on read this verse of the incarnation; some scholars think it a later addition.

Chapter 4

1 She is the book of the commandments of God
and the law that endures to the age.
All who hold her fast are bound for life,
but those who forsake her will die.
2 Turn back, Jacob, and take hold of her;
walk toward her shining, in the face of her light.
3 Do not give your glory to another,
or the things that profit you to a foreign nation.
4 Blessed are we, Israel,
for what is pleasing to God is known to us.

Encouragement for Israel

5 Take courage, my people,
you who keep Israel's name in memory.
6 You were sold to the nations,
not for destruction;
but because you provoked God to anger
you were handed over to your adversaries.
7 You angered your Maker
by offering sacrifices to demons rather than to God.[a]

8 You forgot the everlasting God, who nursed you,
and you grieved Jerusalem, who reared you.
9 For she saw the wrath from God coming upon you,
and said:
Hear, you who dwell near Zion;
God has laid great mourning upon me,
10 for I have seen the captivity of my sons and daughters,
which the Everlasting brought upon them.[b]
11 For with gladness I nursed them,
but with weeping and mourning I sent them away.
12 Let no one rejoice over me, a widow
forsaken by many;
I have been made desolate for the sins of my children,
because they turned aside from the law of God
13 They did not recognize his decrees,
nor follow the paths of his commandments,
nor walk the way of instruction in his righteousness.
14 Let the neighbors of Zion come
and remember the captivity of my sons and daughters,
which the Everlasting brought upon them.
15 For he summoned a nation against them from far away,
a ruthless nation with a foreign language,
that showed no respect for the elderly
and no compassion for the young.[c]
16 And they led away the widow's dear sons
and left her who was alone bereft of her daughters.
17 But I — how can I help you?
18 For the One who brought these evils upon you
will deliver you from the hand of your enemies.
19 Go, children, go on your way,
for I am left desolate.
20 I have removed my garment of peace
and put on sackcloth as I plead;
all my days I will call out to the Eternal One.

21 Take courage, children, cry out to God,
and he will deliver you from tyranny,
from the hand of enemies.
22 My hope is fixed on the Eternal One that he will rescue you,
and delight has come to me from the Holy One
because of the compassion that will quickly reach you
from your eternal Savior.
23 For with mourning and weeping I sent you away,
but God will restore you to me
with joy and gladness to the age.
24 For as the neighbors of Zion have now seen your captivity,
so they will soon see your salvation from God,
which will come upon you with great glory
and with the splendor of the Everlasting.
25 Children, endure patiently
the anger God has brought on you.
Your enemy has chased you down,
but soon you will watch him be destroyed
and tread on his neck.
26 My tender ones have walked rough roads;
they were taken off like a flock carried away by enemies.
27 Be brave, children, and call on God, for the one who sent this upon you will keep you in mind.
28 For as your mind was set on straying from God,
so turn back now with ten times the zeal to seek him.
29 For the One who brought these evils upon you
will bring you everlasting joy along with your salvation.

Jerusalem Comforted

30 Take heart, Jerusalem:
he who named you will give you comfort.
31 Wretched are those who did you harm
and rejoiced at your fall.
32 Wretched are the cities that your children served as slaves;
wretched is she who received your sons.[d]

33 For as she rejoiced at your fall
and was glad over your ruin,
so she will be grieved at her own desolation.
34 And I will take away her delight in her crowds,
and her proud boasting will be turned into mourning.
35 Fire will fall on her from the Eternal One for many days,
and for a long while demons will make their home in her.[e]
36 Turn your eyes eastward, Jerusalem,
and behold the joy that comes to you from God.
37 Look, your sons are on their way, whom you sent off;
they are coming home, assembled from east and west
by the command of the Holy One,
celebrating God's glory.

Notes

- a (4:7) Deut 32:16–17.
- b (4:10) "The Everlasting" (ho aiōnios) is used as a title of God throughout 4:5–5:9.
- c (4:15) Deut 28:49–50.
- d (4:32) Babylon.
- e (4:35) Isa 13:19–22; Jer 50:39.

Chapter 5

1 Take off, Jerusalem, the robe of your mourning and your affliction,
and put on to the age the comeliness of the glory from God.[a]
2 Wrap around yourself the double cloak of the righteousness that is from God;
set on your head the diadem of the glory of the Everlasting.
3 For God will show your brightness
to every place under heaven.
4 For your name will be called by God to the age:
"Peace of Righteousness" and "Glory of Godliness."
5 Rise up, Jerusalem, and stand on the summit;
face east
and watch your children gather from sunset to sunrise
by the command of the Holy One,
rejoicing that God has not forgotten them.

6 They left you on foot,
driven off by their enemies;
but God is bringing them back to you,
lifted up in glory like a royal throne.
7 For God has commanded that every lofty mountain
and the hills of the age be brought low,
and the ravines filled up to make the ground level,
so that in God's glory Israel may go securely.[b]
8 The forests too, and every sweet-smelling tree,
have given Israel shade by God's command.
9 For with joy God will lead Israel
by the light of his glory,
with his own mercy and righteousness.

Notes

- a (5:1) Verses 5:1–9 are close in wording to the Psalms of Solomon 11 (1st century BC); compare Isa 52:1; 60–62.
- b (5:7) Isa 40:4.

Letter of Jeremiah

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 A copy of a letter Jeremiah sent to the people about to be deported
to Babylon by the king of the Babylonians, informing them of what
God had commanded him.[a]
2 Because of the sins you have committed against God, Nebuchadnez-
zar, king of the Babylonians, will deport you to Babylon. 3 So when
you come into Babylon, you will stay there many years and a long
time, up to seven generations;[b] and after this I will bring you out from
there in peace. 4 But now you will see in Babylon gods of silver and
gold and wood carried on shoulders,[c] which put fear into the nations. 5
Be on your guard, then, that you yourselves do not become altogether
like the foreigners, and that fear of them does not seize you 6 when
you see the crowd before and behind them worshiping them. But say
in your mind: "It is you, Master, whom we must worship." 7 For my
angel is with you, and he himself is watching over your lives.[d]
8 Their tongues are polished smooth by a craftsman, and they them-
selves are covered with gold and silver; yet they are fakes and cannot
talk. 9 And taking gold, as for a girl who loves finery, they make
crowns for the heads of their gods. 10 And sometimes the priests even
filch gold and silver from their gods and spend it on themselves, 11
and they will give some of it even to the prostitutes on the roof.[e] And
they deck them out with clothing like human beings — the gods of
silver and gold and wood. 12 Yet these cannot save themselves from
tarnish and moths, though they are wrapped in purple clothing. 13
People wipe their faces because of the dust from the temple, which
lies thick upon them. 14 And one holds a scepter like a man who judges
a land, yet he cannot put to death the one who offends against him.
15 Another has a dagger in his right hand, and an ax, yet he cannot

deliver himself from war and from robbers. 16 From this it is known
that they are not gods; so do not fear them.
17 Just as a vessel someone uses is worthless once it is smashed, so
are their gods once they are installed in their temples. Their eyes are
full of dust kicked up by the feet of visitors. 18 And as the courtyards
are shut up all around a man who has wronged a king and is being
taken off to die, so their priests secure their temples with doors, with
locks and with bars, lest they be plundered by robbers. 19 They light
lamps for them, more than for themselves, though the gods cannot
see a single one of them. 20 They are just like a beam of the temple,
and men say their hearts are eaten out, while creatures that creep
from the ground devour both them and their clothing, and they do
not notice. 21 Their faces are blackened by the smoke from the temple.
22 Upon their bodies and upon their heads light bats, swallows, and
birds, and cats as well.[f] 23 By this you may know that they are no gods;
so have no fear of them.
24 For as for the gold they wear for beauty, unless someone wipes off
the tarnish, they will not shine; for not even when they were being
cast did they feel it. 25 They are bought at any price, though there is
no breath in them. 26 Having no feet, they are carried on shoulders,
showing their own dishonor to human beings; and those who serve
them are put to shame, 27 because if one of them falls to the ground, it
is raised up by them; and if someone sets it upright, it will not move
by itself; and if it is tilted, it cannot straighten itself; but offerings are
set before them as before the dead. 28 And the sacrifices made to them
their priests sell and make use of; and likewise their wives preserve
some of it with salt, but to the poor and helpless they give nothing.
29 A woman in her monthly impurity or in childbed touches their
sacrifices.[g] Knowing, then, from these things that they are not gods,
do not fear them.
30 For how can they be called gods? For women serve meals to gods
of silver and gold and wood. 31 And the priests sit in their houses of
worship with garments rent, heads and beards shorn, bareheaded; 32
they bellow and cry aloud before their gods, like mourners at the meal
for one who has died. 33 The priests take some of their clothing and

dress their own wives and children with it. 34 Whether they suffer evil
from anyone or good, they cannot repay it. They can neither set up
a king nor remove one. 35 Likewise they can give neither wealth nor
a copper coin;[h] if someone makes a vow to them and does not pay it,
they will not call him to account. 36 From death they can save no one,
nor snatch the feeble from the mighty. 37 They cannot bring a blind
man back to sight; they cannot rescue a man who is in distress. 38 They
will not take pity on a widow or do good to an orphan. 39 Like quarried
stones from the hillside are these wooden things, plated over with
gold and silver, and all who serve them will be shamed. 40 How, then,
can anyone imagine them gods or call them so? Even the Chaldeans
themselves show them no respect; 41 for when they meet someone
who is mute and cannot talk, they bring him to Bel[i] and ask that he
speak, as if Bel could grasp it. 42 Yet they themselves cannot perceive
this and forsake them, for they have no sense. 43 And the women, with
cords around them, sit along the roads, burning bran for incense; and
when one of them is drawn aside by some passerby and lies with him,
she taunts the woman beside her, because she was not thought as
worthy as herself and her cord was not broken.[j] 44 All that is done for
them is false. How then can anyone think or call them gods?
45 They are made by carpenters and goldsmiths; they can be nothing
other than what the craftsmen wish them to be. 46 And those who
make them will not themselves last long; how then can the things
made by them be gods? 47 For they have left lies and a reproach to
those who come after. 48 For when war or evils come upon them, the
priests consult together where they may hide themselves with them.
49 How then can one not perceive that they are not gods, who cannot
save themselves from war or from evils? 50 For since they are of wood
and overlaid with gold and silver, it will be known afterward that they
are false. 51 It will be plain to all the nations and the kings that they
are not gods but works of human hands, and that there is no work of
God in them. 52 Who then does not know that they are not gods?
53 For they cannot set up a king over a land, or give rain to human
beings. 54 They are powerless to settle their own case or to rescue a
person who has been wronged; they are like crows flying between

sky and earth.[k] 55 For when fire falls upon a house of gods of wood
or overlaid with gold or silver, their priests will flee and be saved,
but they themselves will be burned up like beams in the middle. 56
And they cannot withstand a king or enemies. How then can anyone
suppose or admit that they are gods? 57 Gods of wood and overlaid
with silver and gold cannot save themselves from thieves and robbers;
58 the strong will strip off their gold and silver and the clothing that
wraps them and go off with it, and they cannot help themselves. 59 So
it is better to be a king who displays his own courage, or a household
jar that serves its owner's needs, than these false gods; or a door
in a house that protects what lies inside, than these false gods; or a
wooden column in a palace, than these false gods.
60 For sun and moon and stars, being bright and sent out for some use,
are obedient. 61 So also the lightning, when it flashes, is fair to see;
and in the same way the wind blows in every land. 62 And when the
clouds are ordered by God to pass over the whole inhabited world,
they carry out the order. 63 And when fire is sent from above to burn
up mountains and forests, it carries out its orders. These idols cannot
compare to them in appearance or in power. 64 Therefore one must
neither think nor call them gods, since they are not able either to
judge a cause or to do good to human beings. 65 Knowing, then, that
they are not gods, do not fear them. 66 For they can neither curse nor
bless kings; 67 They cannot give signs in the sky for the nations, or
shine like the sun, or light up the night like the moon. 68 Better than
they are the beasts of the field, for these can run into a covert and
help themselves. 69 So in no way is it plain to us that they are gods;
therefore do not fear them.
70 For as a scarecrow in a patch of cucumbers[l] keeps no watch over
anything, so are their wooden gods with their gold and silver plating.
71 In the same way their wooden gods, overlaid with gold and silver,
resemble a thornbush in a garden where birds of every kind settle,
or a corpse tossed out in the dark. 72 By the purple and the fine
linen[m] rotting on them you can tell that they are not gods; and they
themselves will finally be devoured and become a disgrace across the

land. [73] Far better is an upright person who owns no idols, for he will be free of disgrace.

Notes

- a (1:1) In the Latin Vulgate and the King James Version this letter is Baruch 6, and its verses are numbered Baruch 6:1–73. Compare the letter of Jer 29:1–23.
- b (1:3) Jer 25:11–12 and 29:10 speak of seventy years; "seven generations" lengthens the exile, perhaps to suit a later author's own time.
- c (1:4) The processions of the Babylonian gods, as at the New Year festival; compare Isa 46:1–7.
- d (1:7) "He himself" is God's angel or God; the Greek is abrupt.
- e (1:11) Literally "on the housetop"; the Greek is obscure, and some render "in the brothel."
- f (1:22) This is the only mention of cats in the Bible.
- g (1:29) Lev 12:2–4; 15:19–24.
- h (1:35) Greek chalkos, a small bronze coin.
- i (1:41) Bel ("lord") is a title of Marduk, the chief god of Babylon; compare Bel and the Dragon. In the Greek, verse 40 runs on into verse 41 without a break.
- j (1:43) Compare the custom described by Herodotus (1.199). The Qumran papyrus 7QpapEpJer gr (7Q2), about 100 BC, preserves parts of verses 43–44 in Greek, as reported.
- k (1:54) The image is obscure: perhaps crows that flit about to no purpose.
- l (1:70) Jer 10:5.
- m (1:72) The Greek reads "marble" (marmaros), probably a corruption; "fine linen" (or "sheen") follows a widely accepted correction, as reported.

Additions to Daniel: Prayer of Azariah and Song of the Three

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

The Prayer of Azariah

1 And they walked about in the midst of the flame, singing hymns to
God and blessing the Lord.[a]
2 And Azariah stood up and prayed thus, and opening his mouth in
the midst of the fire he said:
3 Blessed are you, Lord, God of our fathers,
and praiseworthy, and your name is glorified to the ages.
4 For you are righteous in all that you have done to us,
and all your works are true, and your ways are straight,
and all your judgments are truth.
5 You have carried out true judgments
in everything you have brought down upon us
and upon our ancestors' holy city, Jerusalem;
for with truth and justice you brought all this
upon us because of our sins.
6 For we sinned and did lawlessly in departing from you,
and we sinned in everything,
and to the commandments of your law we did not listen;
7 nor did we keep them or do as you commanded us,
so that it might go well with us.
8 And all that you brought upon us,
and everything that you did to us,
you did in true judgment.
9 And you handed us over into the hands of lawless enemies,
most hateful apostates,
and to a king unjust and the most wicked in all the earth.[b]

10 And now it is not for us to open our mouth;
shame and reproach have come to your slaves
and to those who worship you.
11 Do not hand us over to the end, for your name's sake,
and do not annul your covenant,
12 and do not take your mercy away from us,
for the sake of Abraham, the one beloved by you,
and for the sake of Isaac your servant
and Israel your holy one,
13 to whom you spoke, saying that you would multiply their seed
as the stars of heaven
and as the sand that is on the shore of the sea.[c]
14 For, Master, we have been made fewer than every nation
and are brought low today in all the earth because of our sins.
15 And there is not at this time ruler and prophet and leader,
nor whole burnt offering nor sacrifice nor offering nor incense,
nor a place to bring first fruits before you and find mercy.[d]
16 But with a crushed soul and a humbled spirit may we be received,[e]
17 as with whole burnt offerings of rams and bulls
and as with ten thousands of fat lambs;
so let our sacrifice be before you today
and be fully accomplished behind you,[f]
for there is no shame for those who trust in you.
18 And now we follow you with all our heart,
we revere you and look for your face.
Do not let us be disgraced,
19 but treat us with your kindness
and with your overflowing compassion.
20 And rescue us according to your wonders,
and give glory to your name, Lord.
21 And let all who show evil to your slaves be turned back,
and let them be put to shame, stripped of all power,
and let their strength be crushed;
22 and let them know that you alone are Lord God,
and glorious over the whole inhabited world.

The Furnace 23 And the king's servants who had thrown them in did
not stop heating the furnace with naphtha and pitch and tow and
brushwood. 24 And the flame poured out above the furnace to about
seventy-three feet;[g] 25 and it spread out and burned up those of the
Chaldeans whom it found around the furnace. 26 But the angel of the
Lord came down together with those around Azariah into the furnace
and shook the flame of the fire out of the furnace, 27 and made the
middle of the furnace as if a wind of dew were whistling through it;
and the fire did not touch them at all, nor give them pain, nor trouble
them.

The Song of the Three

28 Then the three, as from one mouth, sang a hymn and glorified and
blessed God in the furnace, saying:

29 Blessed are you, Lord, God of our fathers,
and praiseworthy and exalted above all to the ages;
30 and blessed is the holy name of your glory,
and greatly praised and exalted above all to all the ages.
31 Blessed are you in the temple of your holy glory,
and hymned above all and glorified above all to the ages.[h]
32 Blessed are you who look upon the abysses,
seated on the cherubim,
and praiseworthy and exalted above all to the ages.
33 Blessed are you on the throne of your kingship,
and hymned above all and exalted above all to the ages.
34 Blessed are you in the firmament of heaven,
and hymned and glorified to the ages.
35 Bless the Lord, all you works of the Lord;[i]
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
36 Bless the Lord, you heavens;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
37 Bless the Lord, you angels of the Lord;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
38 Bless the Lord, all you waters above the heaven;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.

39 Bless the Lord, all you powers;[j]
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
40 Bless the Lord, sun and moon;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
41 Bless the Lord, you stars of heaven;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
42 Bless the Lord, every shower and dew;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
43 Bless the Lord, all you winds;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
44 Bless the Lord, fire and burning heat;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
45 Bless the Lord, chill and scorching;[k]
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
46 Bless the Lord, dews and snowfalls;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
47 Bless the Lord, nights and days;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
48 Bless the Lord, light and darkness;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
49 Bless the Lord, frost and cold;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
50 Bless the Lord, hoarfrosts and snows;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
51 Bless the Lord, lightnings and clouds;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
52 Let the earth bless the Lord;
let it hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
53 Bless the Lord, mountains and hills;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
54 Bless the Lord, all things that spring up on the earth;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
55 Bless the Lord, you springs;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.

56 Bless the Lord, seas and rivers;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
57 Bless the Lord, you sea monsters[l] and all things that move in the waters;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
58 Bless the Lord, all you birds of heaven;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
59 Bless the Lord, you wild beasts and all you cattle;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
60 Bless the Lord, you sons of human beings;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
61 Bless the Lord, Israel;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
62 Bless the Lord, you priests of the Lord;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
63 Bless the Lord, you slaves of the Lord;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
64 Bless the Lord, you spirits and souls of the righteous;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
65 Bless the Lord, you who are holy and lowly in heart;
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages.
66 Bless the Lord, Hananiah, Azariah, Mishael;[m]
hymn him and exalt him above all to the ages;
for he has drawn us out of Hades
and saved us from the hand of death
and rescued us from the midst of the burning flame
and from the midst of the fire he rescued us.
67 Give thanks to the Lord, for he is kind,
for his mercy is to the ages.[n]
68 Bless, all you who revere the Lord, the God of gods;
hymn him and give thanks,
for his mercy is to the ages.[o]

Notes

- a (1:1) Inserted after Dan 3:23. The Old Greek opens instead: "So Hananiah and Azariah and Mishael prayed and sang hymns to the Lord when the king commanded that they be thrown into the furnace."
- b (1:9) Nebuchadnezzar, or, in the author's own day, perhaps Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–164 BC).
- c (1:13) Gen 15:5; 22:17.
- d (1:15) Compare Hos 3:4. The line fits the time when the temple worship was halted (167–164 BC; 1 Macc 1:41–64), as many hold.
- e (1:16) Ps 51:17.
- f (1:17) The Greek line "and be fully accomplished behind you" (ekteleisai opisthen sou) is obscure; the Old Greek, as reported, reads differently here, and some correct the text to "and may we wholly follow you."
- g (1:24) Greek "forty-nine cubits," about 22 m; a cubit is about 18 inches (45 cm).
- h (1:31) The order of verses 31–34 differs somewhat between Theodotion and the Old Greek, as reported.
- i (1:35) Verses 35–68 are the canticle known from its Latin opening as the Benedicite. The refrain renders hymneite kai hyperypsoute auton eis tous aiōnas.
- j (1:39) The heavenly hosts.
- k (1:45) The sequence of the elements named in verses 42–51 differs between Theodotion and the Old Greek, as reported.
- l (1:57) Greek kētē, the great creatures of the sea, including whales.
- m (1:66) Dan 1:6–7: Shadrach, Abednego and Meshach.
- n (1:67) Ps 136:1.
- o (1:68) The Greek and Latin text of Daniel continues at 3:24 of the Hebrew-Aramaic ("Then King Nebuchadnezzar was astonished…"), numbered Dan 3:91 in the Vulgate.

Additions to Daniel: Susanna

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 There was a man living in Babylon, and his name was Joakim.[a] 2 And he took a wife whose name was Susanna,[b] daughter of Hilkiah, very beautiful and one who feared the Lord. 3 Her parents, too, were just people, and they had instructed their daughter in keeping with Moses' law. 4 Joakim was extremely wealthy, and next to his house he had a garden; the Jews regularly visited him, since he was the most respected of all of them.

5 And two elders from the people were appointed judges in that year, about whom the Master had spoken: "Lawlessness came out of Babylon, from elders who were judges, who seemed to guide the people."[c] 6 These men spent much time in Joakim's house, and all who had cases to be judged would come to them there. 7 And when the people went away at midday, Susanna would go in and walk about in her husband's garden. 8 And the two elders watched her every day going in and walking about, and they came to be in lust for her. 9 And they twisted their own minds and turned their eyes away so as not to look to heaven or remember just judgments. 10 And both were pierced with desire for her, yet they did not disclose their pain to each other, 11 for they were ashamed to disclose their lust, that they wished to lie with her. 12 And they watched eagerly every day to see her. 13 They said to each other, "Let's go home; it is time for lunch." So they left and separated. 14 And turning back they came to the same place, and when they questioned each other about the reason, they owned up to their lust. And then together they fixed a time when they would be able to find her alone.

15 And it happened, while they were watching for a fit day, that she went in as on the day before and the day before that, with only two maidservants, and she wished to bathe in the garden, for it was hot.[d]

16 And there was no one there except the two elders, who had hidden
and were watching her. 17 And she said to the maids, “Bring me olive
oil and soap, and shut the doors of the garden, so that I may bathe.”
18 And they did just as she told them: they closed the garden doors,
then slipped out through the side doors to fetch what she had asked
for; and the elders they never saw, since these were in hiding. 19 And
it happened, when the maids had gone out, that the two elders got up
and ran to her and said, 20 “Look, the doors of the garden are shut, and
no one sees us, and we are in desire for you; so agree with us and be
with us. 21 But if not, we will testify against you that a young man was
with you and that this is why you sent the maids away from you.”
22 Susanna groaned and said, “I am trapped on all sides. If I do this,
it means my death; if I refuse, I will not get away from you. 23 Better
that I refrain and fall into your hands than that I sin in the Lord’s
sight.” 24 Then Susanna shouted aloud, and the pair of elders shouted
out against her as well. 25 And one of them ran and opened the doors
of the garden. 26 And when those in the house heard the outcry in the
garden, they rushed in by the side door to see what had happened
to her. 27 And when the elders told their tale, the slaves were deeply
ashamed, for never had such a word been spoken about Susanna.
28 And it happened on the next day, when the people gathered to her
husband Joakim, that the two elders came, full of their lawless intent
against Susanna, to have her put to death. 29 And they said before the
people, “Send for Susanna, daughter of Hilkiah, who is Joakim’s wife.”
And they sent. 30 And she came, and her parents and her children and
all her relatives. 31 Now Susanna was exceedingly delicate and beau-
tiful in appearance. 32 And the lawless men ordered her to be unveiled,
for she was veiled, so that they might take their fill of her beauty. 33
And those with her and all who saw her were weeping. 34 Then the
pair of elders rose in the middle of the people and placed their hands
on her head.[e] 35 But she, in tears, gazed up heavenward, because her
heart had put its trust in the Lord. 36 And the elders said, “While we
were walking about in the garden by ourselves, this woman came in
with two maids, and she shut the doors of the garden and sent the
maids away. 37 Then a youth, who was lying hidden there, approached

her and lay with her. 38 And we were in a corner of the garden, and
seeing the lawlessness we ran to them; 39 and though we saw the two
of them together, we could not hold him, since he was stronger than
we were; he opened the doors and sprang out. 40 But we seized this
woman and questioned her as to who the young man was, 41 and she
refused to tell us. This is our testimony." Because they were elders
and judges of the people, the assembly believed them and sentenced
her to death.
42 And Susanna cried out with a loud voice and said, "God of the age,
who knows hidden things, who knows all things before they come
to be, 43 you know that they have testified falsely against me. And
see, I am dying, though I have done none of the things that these
men have wickedly made up against me." 44 And the Lord heard her
voice. 45 And as she was being led away to be destroyed, God stirred
up the holy spirit of a young boy whose name was Daniel,[f] 46 and he
shouted with a loud voice, "I am clean of the blood of this woman!"
47 Then the whole people swung round toward him and said, "What
is this you have just said?" 48 And he, standing in their midst, said,
"Are you such fools, sons of Israel? Without examining and without
learning the plain truth, have you condemned a daughter of Israel? 49
Go back to the place of judgment, for these men have testified falsely
against her."
50 So the whole people hurried back. And the elders said to him,
"Come, take your seat in our midst and make it known to us, since
God has granted you the rank of an elder." 51 Daniel said to them, "Set
the two a good distance apart, one from the other, and I will put them
to the question." 52 And when they had been separated one from the
other, he called one of them and said to him, "You who have grown old
in days of evil, now your sins have come home, which you committed
before, 53 judging unjust judgments, condemning the innocent and
letting the guilty go free, though the Lord says, 'The innocent and the
righteous you shall not kill.'[g] 54 Now then, if you really saw her, tell
me: under what tree did you see them having intercourse with each
other?" And he said, "Under a mastic tree."[h] 55 And Daniel said, "Well
have you lied against your own head; for already the angel of God

has received the sentence from God and will split you in two." 56 And putting him aside, he ordered them to bring the other, and said to him, "Offspring of Canaan and not of Judah, beauty has deceived you, and desire has twisted your heart. 57 This is how you were dealing with the daughters of Israel, and they were having intercourse with you out of fear; but a daughter of Judah would not endure your lawlessness. 58 Now tell me: beneath which tree did you see them having sex?" He answered, "Under an evergreen oak."[i] 59 And Daniel said to him, "Well have you too lied against your own head; for the angel of God is waiting with the sword to saw you in two, so as to destroy you both." 60 And the whole assembly cried out with a loud voice and blessed God, who saves those who hope in him. 61 And they rose up against the two elders, because Daniel had convicted them out of their own mouth of having testified falsely, and they did to them just as they had wickedly planned to do to their neighbor; 62 acting according to the law of Moses,[j] they killed them. And innocent blood was saved on that day. 63 And Hilkiah and his wife gave praise for their daughter, with Joakim her husband and all her relatives, because nothing shameful was found in her. 64 And Daniel became great before the people from that day onward.[k]

Notes

- a (1:1) In the Latin Vulgate and Catholic Bibles this book is Daniel 13. Verses 1–5a are lacking in the Old Greek, which begins abruptly with the elders.
- b (1:2) Hebrew shoshannah, "lily."
- c (1:5) The saying is not found in the Old Testament; some compare Jer 29:20–23, where two false prophets in Babylon, Ahab and Zedekiah, are condemned for adultery.
- d (1:15) Verses 15–18 have no counterpart in the Old Greek, which tells the story without the bath.
- e (1:34) Lev 24:14.
- f (1:45) The Old Greek, as reported, reads instead that "an angel of the Lord gave a spirit of understanding to a young man," Daniel.
- g (1:53) Exod 23:7.
- h (1:54) Greek schinos, the mastic or lentisk, a small evergreen shrub. Daniel answers with a pun: schinos / schisei, "will split." An English imitation would be "under a clove tree … the angel will cleave you."

- i (1:58) Greek prinos, the holm oak (Quercus ilex). The pun is prinos / prisai, “to saw.” An English imitation would be “under a yew … to hew you.”
- j (1:62) Deut 19:16–21. The Old Greek, as reported, says that they gagged them, led them out, and threw them into a ravine, and that the angel of the Lord cast fire between them.
- k (1:64) The Old Greek ends instead with praise of the young: “For this reason the young are beloved of Jacob for their simplicity…,” as reported.

Additions to Daniel: Bel and the Dragon

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

Bel 1 King Astyages was gathered to his fathers, and Cyrus the Persian
received his kingdom.[a] 2 And Daniel lived as a companion of the king
and was honored above all his Friends.[b] 3 And the Babylonians had an
idol whose name was Bel,[c] and there were spent on it each day twelve
artabas of fine flour and forty sheep and six measures of wine. 4 And
the king revered it and would go each day to bow down to it, but
Daniel bowed down to his own God. 5 And the king said to him, "Why
do you not bow down to Bel?" And he said, "Because I do not revere
idols made by hand, but the living God, who created the heaven
and the earth and has lordship over all flesh." 6 The king asked him,
"Don't you agree that Bel is a living god? Can't you see how much he
consumes every day?" 7 Daniel laughed and said, "Let no one mislead
you, O king: this thing is clay within and bronze without, and never
has it eaten or drunk a thing." 8 The king was furious and summoned
his priests. He told them, "Unless you tell me who is consuming these
supplies, you will die. 9 But if you can prove that Bel consumes them,
Daniel will die, because he has insulted Bel." Daniel told the king, "Let
it be as you say."

10 Now the priests of Bel were seventy, besides their wives and
children. And the king went with Daniel into the house of Bel. 11 And
the priests of Bel said, "See, we are going outside; and you, O king,
set out the food and mix the wine and put it out, and shut the door
and seal it with your signet ring. 12 Come in at dawn tomorrow, and if
you do not find that Bel has eaten everything, we will die—otherwise
Daniel, who is lying about us, will." 13 But they were unconcerned, for
they had made a hidden entrance under the table, and through it they

would go in continually and consume the things. 14 And it happened,
when they had gone out, that the king set out the food for Bel. And
Daniel ordered his servants, and they brought ashes and sifted them
through the whole temple in the presence of the king alone. And they
went out and shut the door and sealed it with the king's signet ring
and departed. 15 And the priests came in the night, as was their habit,
with their wives and children, and they ate and drank everything up.
16 And the king rose early in the morning, and Daniel with him. 17
And he said, "Are the seals unbroken, Daniel?" And he said, "They
are unbroken, O king." 18 And it happened, as soon as the doors were
opened, that the king looked at the table and cried out with a loud
voice, "Great are you, Bel, and with you there is no deceit, not even
one!" 19 And Daniel laughed and held back the king from going in, and
said, "Look now at the floor and take note whose footprints these are."
20 The king said, "I see the tracks of men, of women, and of children."
21 The king was furious; he arrested the priests along with their wives
and children, and they pointed out the secret doors by which they
entered to eat what was set on the table. 22 And the king killed them
and handed Bel over to Daniel, and he overturned it and its temple.[d]
The Dragon 23 And there was a great dragon,[e] and the Babylonians
revered it. 24 And the king said to Daniel, "You will not say that this
one too is bronze! See, it lives and eats and drinks; you cannot say
that this is not a living god. So bow down to it." 25 And Daniel said, "I
will bow down to the Lord my God, for he is a living God. 26 But you,
O king, give me authority, and I will kill the dragon without sword or
rod." And the king said, "I give it to you." 27 And Daniel took pitch and
fat and hair, and boiled them together and made cakes and put them
into the dragon's mouth; and the dragon ate and burst open. And he
said, "See the things you revere!"
28 And it happened, when the Babylonians heard it, that they were
greatly indignant and gathered against the king and said, "The king
has become a Jew! He has torn down Bel and killed the dragon and
slaughtered the priests." 29 And they came to the king and said, "Hand
Daniel over to us; otherwise we will kill you and your household." 30
And the king saw that they pressed him hard, and being forced, he

handed Daniel over to them. 31 And they threw him into the lions' pit,
and he was there six days.[f] 32 And in the pit there were seven lions, and
they had been given every day two bodies and two sheep; but at that
time they were not given them, so that they would devour Daniel.
33 Now the prophet Habakkuk was in Judea;[g] he had cooked a stew,
crumbled bread into a bowl, and was heading to the field to bring
it to the harvesters. 34 And the angel of the Lord said to Habakkuk,
"Take the meal that you have to Babylon, to Daniel, into the lions'
pit." 35 Habakkuk said, "Lord, Babylon I have never laid eyes on, and
the pit I do not know." 36 And the angel of the Lord took hold of
the crown of his head, and carrying him by the hair of his head, set
him down in Babylon above the pit, in the rush of his spirit.[h] 37 And
Habakkuk shouted, saying, "Daniel, Daniel, take the meal that God
has sent you!" 38 And Daniel said, "For you have remembered me, O
God, and you have not forsaken those who love you." 39 And Daniel
got up and ate; and the angel of God at once returned Habakkuk to
his own place.
40 And on the seventh day the king came to mourn Daniel, and he
came to the pit and looked in, and there sat Daniel. 41 Then the king
shouted, "You are great, Lord, God of Daniel, and there is no god but
you!" 42 And he drew him out, and the ones who had been the cause
of his ruin he threw into the pit, and they were devoured instantly
before his face.[i]

Notes

- a (1:1) In the Latin Vulgate and Catholic Bibles this book is Daniel 14. Astyages, the last king of the Medes, was overthrown by Cyrus about 550 BC; Cyrus took Babylon in 539 BC. The Old Greek has no such opening. After its title, it begins by introducing a priest named Daniel, son of Abal, who was a companion of the king of Babylon.
- b (1:2) "Friends" was a court title.
- c (1:3) Bel ("lord") is Marduk, the god of Babylon. Twelve artabas are about 19 bushels (about 670 liters); six metrētai are about 60 gallons (about 230 liters), as these measures are usually reckoned.
- d (1:22) The Old Greek, as reported, says that the king handed Bel over to Daniel and that Daniel destroyed it.

- e (1:23) Greek drakōn, a great serpent. The cult of a living serpent is otherwise unattested at Babylon; compare the mušḫuššu dragon of Marduk on the Ishtar Gate.
- f (1:31) Compare Dan 6:16–24, where Daniel spends one night with the lions under Darius.
- g (1:33) The prophet of the book of Habakkuk, of the late 7th century BC.
- h (1:36) Compare Ezek 8:3. "His spirit" may be the angel's or God's.
- i (1:42) Compare Dan 6:24. The Old Greek, as reported, ends with the king's praise of "the Lord God" and adds no further notice.

1 Maccabees

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 After Alexander son of Philip, the Macedonian,[a] who had come out
of the land of the Kittim,[b] had defeated Darius, king of the Persians
and the Medes, he became king in his place, having first ruled over
Greece.[c] 2 He fought many wars, seized fortresses, and put kings to
death. 3 He pushed on to the far ends of the earth and plundered a
host of nations. When the earth fell silent before him, he grew proud,
and his heart swelled with arrogance. 4 He built up a very powerful
army and ruled over lands, nations and princes, who paid him tribute.
5 After this he took to his bed and knew that he was dying. 6 So he
called in his officers, the nobles who had grown up with him from
boyhood, and while he was still alive he split his kingdom among
them. 7 Alexander had reigned twelve years when he died.[d] 8 Then his
officers took control, each in his own territory. 9 When he died, they
all put on royal crowns, as did their sons for many years after them,
and they brought great suffering to the earth.
10 From them sprang a sinful shoot: Antiochus Epiphanes,[e] King
Antiochus's son, who had once been held hostage at Rome. He took
the throne in the year 137 of the kingdom of the Greeks (175 BC).[f]
11 In those days some renegades came out of Israel and persuaded
many, saying, "Come, let us make a treaty with the nations around
us, for ever since we kept ourselves apart from them, many troubles
have overtaken us." 12 The proposal pleased them, 13 and a number of
the people were quick to go to the king, who gave them permission
to adopt the customs of the Gentiles. 14 So they built a gymnasium[g] in
Jerusalem in keeping with Gentile custom, 15 disguised their circum-
cision,[h] and abandoned the holy covenant. They joined themselves to
the Gentiles and sold themselves to do evil.

16 When Antiochus saw that his rule was secure, he set his mind on
becoming king of the land of Egypt as well, so that he might rule
over both kingdoms. 17 He invaded Egypt with a massive force, with
chariots, elephants, cavalry, and a large fleet. 18 He waged war against
Ptolemy king of Egypt,[i] and Ptolemy turned back before him and fled,
and many fell wounded. 19 They captured the fortified cities in the
land of Egypt, and he carried off the plunder of the land.
20 After his conquest of Egypt, Antiochus turned back in the year 143
(169 BC).[j] He marched against Israel, coming up to Jerusalem with a
massive force. 21 In his pride he entered the sanctuary and carried off
the golden altar,[k] the lampstand that gave light, and all its equipment,
22 the table for the bread of the Presence,[l] the libation cups and bowls,
the gold censers, the curtain, and the crowns; and he peeled away
all the gilded decoration from the temple's facade. 23 He took the
silver and the gold and the precious vessels, and he took whatever
hidden treasures he found. 24 Gathering everything up, he went back
to his own land. He had committed murder and had spoken with
great arrogance. 25 Deep grief came over Israel in every place where
they lived. 26 Leaders and elders groaned; girls and youths lost their
strength; the women's beauty faded. 27 Every bridegroom took up a
lament, and the bride sitting in her chamber went into mourning. 28
The land quaked for those who lived in it, and the whole house of
Jacob was clothed in shame.
29 Two years later the king sent a chief tax collector[m] to the cities of
Judah, and he came to Jerusalem with a massive force. 30 He spoke
to them with peaceful words, but deceitfully, and they believed him.
Then he fell on the city without warning, dealt it a heavy blow, and
killed many people of Israel. 31 He looted the city and burned it, and he
demolished its houses and the walls that surrounded it. 32 Women and
children they carried away as captives, and the cattle they took for
themselves. 33 Next they walled the City of David with a strong, high
wall and powerful towers, and they used it as their fortress.[n] 34 They
stationed a sinful people there, lawless men, and these entrenched
themselves in it. 35 They stocked it with weapons and provisions,
and they collected the spoils of Jerusalem and stored them there. It

became a dangerous snare, [36] an ambush against the sanctuary, an evil adversary[o] to Israel at all times. [37] Around the sanctuary they shed innocent blood, and they defiled the sanctuary. [38] Because of them the people of Jerusalem fled. The city became a home for foreigners; it became foreign to its own offspring, and its children abandoned it. [39] Her sanctuary lay as barren as a desert; her festivals were turned to mourning, her sabbaths to disgrace, and her honor to scorn. [40] Her disgrace became as great as her glory had been, and her exaltation was turned into mourning.

[41] Then the king wrote to his whole kingdom that all should be one people [42] and that each should give up their own customs. All the nations accepted the king's command. [43] Many Israelites, too, were content with his cult: they offered sacrifices to idols and desecrated the sabbath. [44] The king also sent letters by messengers to Jerusalem and the cities of Judah, ordering them to follow customs foreign to the land: [45] to end the whole burnt offerings, sacrifices and drink offerings in the sanctuary, and to defile the sabbaths and festivals, [46] to defile the sanctuary and those who were holy, [47] to build altars, sacred precincts, and idol shrines, to sacrifice pigs and other unclean animals, [48] and to leave their sons uncircumcised. They were to make themselves abhorrent with every kind of impurity and profanation, [49] so that they would forget the law and change all its ordinances. [50] Whoever did not obey the king's command was to die.

[51] In words like these he wrote to his whole kingdom. He appointed inspectors over all the people and ordered the cities of Judah to offer sacrifice, city by city. [52] Many of the people flocked to them, all who were deserting the law, and they wrought evil in the land. [53] They drove Israel into hiding in every place where they could take refuge. [54] On the fifteenth day of Kislev (in November–December), in the year 145 (167 BC),[p] they set up a desolating abomination[q] on the altar of burnt offering, and they built altars in the towns all around Judah. [55] They burned incense at the doors of houses and in the streets. [56] Any books of the law they found, they tore up and burned. [57] Anyone found possessing a book of the covenant, and anyone who kept to the law, was put to death by the king's decree. [58] Month after month they

used their power against the Israelites who were found in the towns.
59 On the twenty-fifth day of each month they offered sacrifices on the
pagan altar that had been placed on top of the altar of burnt offering.[r]
60 As the decree required, they executed women who had circumcised
their children, 61 and they hung the infants from their mothers' necks;
they also killed their families and those who had circumcised them. 62
Yet many in Israel held firm and made up their minds that they would
not eat anything unclean. 63 They chose to die rather than be defiled
by food or profane the holy covenant, and they died. 64 Very great
wrath came upon Israel.[s]

Notes

- a (1:1) Alexander the Great (356–323 BC), son of Philip II of Macedon. The name Alexander means "defender of men."
- b (1:1) Greek Chettiim. The Kittim were originally the people of Kition in Cyprus; the name came to be used for the peoples of the west across the sea, here the Macedonians and Greeks.
- c (1:1) Or "he became king in his place, the first to rule over Greece." The sense of the Greek is uncertain; Alexander ruled Greece before defeating Darius III of Persia (331 BC).
- d (1:7) Alexander reigned 336–323 BC.
- e (1:10) Antiochus IV (reigned 175–164 BC). Epiphanes means "manifest," a title claiming that a god was made visible in him.
- f (1:10) Greek: in the 137th year of the kingdom of the Greeks, that is, the Seleucid era, which began with Seleucus I. 1 Maccabees generally counts its years from the spring of 311 BC, so year 137 ran from spring 175 to spring 174 BC. Some of its dates appear to use the reckoning from autumn 312 BC, and dates converted here may be a year off.
- g (1:14) A Greek athletic and educational center, where men exercised naked.
- h (1:15) Literally "made foreskins for themselves," that is, they underwent a procedure to hide their circumcision.
- i (1:18) Ptolemy VI Philometor (reigned 180–145 BC).
- j (1:20) Greek: in the 143rd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- k (1:21) The altar of incense, overlaid with gold (Exodus 30:1–10).
- l (1:22) Literally "the table of the setting out," the table for the sacred loaves (Exodus 25:23–30).
- m (1:29) Literally "a ruler of tribute." 2 Maccabees 5:24 names him Apollonius, the commander of the Mysians.
- n (1:33) Greek akra. The Akra was a fortress near the temple held by Seleucid troops until Simon captured it in 141 BC (13:49–51). Its exact location is debated.
- o (1:36) Greek diabolos, "slanderer" or "adversary."

- p (1:54) Greek: the fifteenth day of Chaseleu (the Hebrew month Kislev, the ninth month), in the 145th year of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:10). The year ran from spring 167 to spring 166 BC, so this was December 167 BC.
- q (1:54) Greek bdelygma erēmōseōs, the "abomination of desolation" of Daniel 9:27; 11:31; 12:11 (compare Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14). It was probably a pagan altar or sacred object set on top of the altar of burnt offering (see 1:59; 6:7). 2 Maccabees 6:2 says the temple was rededicated to Olympian Zeus. The Hebrew phrase in Daniel (shiqquts shomem) may be a mocking wordplay on Baal Shamem, "lord of heaven."
- r (1:59) That is, on the twenty-fifth of Kislev, December 167 BC. Exactly three years later the temple was rededicated on the same day (4:52–54).
- s (1:64) Or "Very great wrath was upon Israel." The wrath may be God's or the persecutor's.

Chapter 2

1 At that time Mattathias[a] son of John, son of Simeon, a priest descended from Joarib,[b] left Jerusalem and made his home at Modein.[c]
2 He had five sons: John, called Gaddi; 3 Simon, called Thassi; 4 Judas, called Maccabeus;[d] 5 Eleazar, called Avaran; and Jonathan, called Apphus.[e]
6 He saw the blasphemous things being done in Judah and in Jerusalem, 7 and he said, "What a tragedy! Why was I born to see my people and the holy city ruined, and to sit by while the city is delivered to its enemies and the sanctuary to outsiders? 8 Her temple has become like a man disgraced;[f] 9 the vessels that were her glory have been carried off as captives. Her infants have been killed in her streets, her young men by the enemy's sword. 10 What nation has not taken a share of her royal possessions[g] and not seized her plunder? 11 All her ornaments have been stripped away; she was free, and now she is a slave. 12 Look at it! Our holy place, our beauty and our glory lie in ruins, and the Gentiles have defiled them. 13 Why should we go on living?" 14 Mattathias and his sons then tore their garments, wrapped themselves in sackcloth, and wept bitterly.
15 The king's officers who were forcing the people to abandon their religion came to the town of Modein to make them offer sacrifice. 16 Many from Israel went over to them, but Mattathias and his sons gathered together. 17 Then the king's officers spoke to Mattathias and said, "You are a leader in this town, honored and great, and supported

by sons and brothers. 18 So come forward now and carry out the king's
order, as all the nations have, along with the leading men of Judah
and those still left in Jerusalem. You and your household will then be
counted as Friends of the King,[h] and silver, gold and many gifts will
be your reward, yours and your sons'." 19 But Mattathias answered in a
loud voice, "Even if all the nations within the king's realm obey him,
each of them forsaking the worship of their ancestors and choosing
to follow his commands, 20 still I, my sons, and my brothers will walk
in our ancestors' covenant. 21 Heaven forbid that we should abandon
the law and its ordinances! 22 The king's words we will not heed, nor
will we swerve from our worship to the right or to the left."
23 As soon as he had said this, a Jew stepped forward in full view of
everyone to offer a sacrifice on the altar at Modein, as the king had
ordered. 24 Mattathias saw it and was fired with zeal; he trembled to
his depths[i] and let his rightful anger rise. Running forward, he cut
the man down on the altar. 25 He also killed the royal officer who was
forcing people to sacrifice, then and there, and he pulled the altar
down. 26 So he showed his zeal for the law, as Phinehas had done to
Zimri son of Salu.[j]
27 Then Mattathias cried out in the town with a loud voice, "Everyone
who is zealous for the law and upholds the covenant, come out and
follow me!" 28 He and his sons fled to the hills, leaving behind every-
thing they owned in the town.
29 Then many who sought righteousness and justice went down into
the desert to make their homes there, 30 they and their sons, their
wives, and their livestock, because hardships pressed hard on them. 31
Word came to the king's officers and to the soldiers in Jerusalem, the
City of David, that men who had disobeyed the king's command had
gone to hide in the wilderness. 32 Many hurried after them, overtook
them, and camped opposite them. They prepared to attack them on
the sabbath day. 33 "Enough!" they told them. "Come out, obey the
king's word, and live." 34 "We will not come out," they replied, "and we
will not obey the king's word and desecrate the sabbath day." 35 Then
the enemy quickly attacked them. 36 But they did not answer them;
they did not hurl a stone at them or block up their hiding places. 37

They said, “Let us all die with clean hands. Heaven and earth are our witnesses that you are killing us unjustly.” 38 So the enemy attacked them on the sabbath, and about a thousand of them died, along with their wives, children and livestock.

39 When Mattathias and his friends learned of it, they grieved deeply for them. 40 They said to each other, “If we all follow the example of our brothers and will not fight the Gentiles for our lives and our laws, they will quickly erase us from the earth.” 41 So that day they resolved, “If anyone comes to attack us on the sabbath day, let us fight against him, so that we do not all die as our brothers died in their hiding places.”

42 Then a band of Hasideans[k] joined them, strong fighters from Israel, every one of them devoted to the law of his own free will. 43 Everyone who had fled from the troubles joined them and strengthened them. 44 They raised an army and, in their anger, cut down sinners and, in their fury, those who broke the law; the survivors escaped to the Gentiles to be safe. 45 Mattathias and his sons went around and tore down the altars, 46 and every uncircumcised boy they came upon inside Israel’s territory they circumcised by force. 47 They pursued the proud, and the work went well under their hands. 48 They rescued the law from the power of the Gentiles and of kings, and they did not let the sinner triumph.[l]

49 As the days of Mattathias’s death drew near, he told his sons, “Now arrogance and rebuke have taken firm hold; it is a season of overthrow and blazing wrath. 50 Now, my children, be zealous for the law, and give your lives for the covenant of our ancestors. 51 Remember the deeds our ancestors did in their generations, and you will win great honor and an everlasting name. 52 Was not Abraham found faithful when he was tested, and it was credited to him as righteousness?[m] 53 Joseph kept the commandment in his time of distress and became lord of Egypt. 54 Phinehas our forefather, for his burning zeal, was granted the covenant of an everlasting priesthood.[n] 55 Joshua,[o] because he carried out the command, became a judge in Israel. 56 Caleb, for testifying before the congregation, was given land as his heritage. 57 David, for his mercy, inherited a royal throne forever. 58 Elijah, because

of his great zeal for the law, was taken up into heaven. [59] Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael believed and were saved from the flame.[p] [60] Daniel, because of his innocence, was rescued from the mouth of the lions. [61] So consider this, generation after generation: none who hope in him will lack strength. [62] Do not fear the words of a sinner, for his glory will end in dung and worms. [63] He is honored today, but tomorrow he will be nowhere to be found; he has gone back to dust, and his plans have come to nothing. [64] My children, be strong and courageous for the law, for by it you will gain glory.

[65] "Here is your brother Simeon.[q] I know he is a man of good counsel; always listen to him. He will be a father to you. [66] Judas Maccabeus, strong and mighty since boyhood, shall lead your army and wage the war against the peoples.[r] [67] Gather around you all who observe the law, and avenge the wrongs done to your people. [68] Pay back the Gentiles in full, and hold fast to the commands of the law."

[69] Then he blessed them and was gathered to his ancestors. [70] He died in the year 146 (166 BC),[s] and his sons buried him in his ancestors' tomb at Modein. All Israel mourned him deeply.

Notes

- a (2:1) Mattathias (Hebrew Mattithyahu) means "gift of Yahweh." His family is known as the Hasmoneans, after an ancestor named Hasmon (Josephus, Antiquities 12.265).
- b (2:1) Joarib is the priestly family of Jehoiarib (1 Chronicles 24:7), the first of the twenty-four priestly divisions. Joarib means "Yahweh contends."
- c (2:1) Modein was a village about 17 miles (27 km) northwest of Jerusalem.
- d (2:4) Maccabeus is usually explained as "the hammer" (from Hebrew or Aramaic maqqabah), but the meaning is uncertain; other proposals include "designated by Yahweh." The meanings of the other sons' nicknames (Gaddi, Thassi, Avaran, Apphus) are unknown. The sons' names: John means "Yahweh is gracious," Simon "he has heard," Judas (Judah) "praised," Eleazar "God has helped," Jonathan "Yahweh has given."
- e (2:5) Avaran may mean "the piercer," and Apphus "the wary one," but these meanings are uncertain.
- f (2:8) The Greek text reads "like a man of honor," which does not fit the context; many editors read "like a man without honor" (adoxos for endoxos), followed here.
- g (2:10) Or "her palaces"; the Greek basileia can mean either.
- h (2:18) A formal rank at the Seleucid court, bestowing honors and privileges.

- i (2:24) Literally "his kidneys trembled," the kidneys being thought the seat of deep emotion.
- j (2:26) Numbers 25:6–15. Salu (Greek Salom) was Zimri's father.
- k (2:42) Greek Asidaioi, from Hebrew hasidim, "the devout" or "the loyal ones," a group devoted to strict observance of the law.
- l (2:48) Literally "did not give a horn to the sinner." The horn is a symbol of strength.
- m (2:52) Genesis 15:6; 22:1–18.
- n (2:54) Numbers 25:13.
- o (2:55) Greek Iēsous, the Greek form of Joshua. Joshua means "Yahweh saves."
- p (2:59) Daniel 3, where they are known by their Babylonian names Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.
- q (2:65) That is, Simon (2:3); Simeon is the fuller form of the name.
- r (2:66) Or "fight the people's battle." The Greek is ambiguous.
- s (2:70) Greek: in the 146th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10), from spring 166 to spring 165 BC.

Chapter 3

1 Then his son Judas, who was called Maccabeus, rose up to take his
place. 2 All his brothers stood by him, as did all who had attached
themselves to his father, and they fought Israel's battle gladly. 3 He
spread his people's glory far and wide. Like a giant he put on his
breastplate; he strapped on his weapons of war and fought battle after
battle, guarding the camp with his sword. 4 In his exploits he was like
a lion, like a lion's whelp roaring over its prey. 5 He tracked down the
lawless and hunted them out, and he gave to the flames those who
troubled his people. 6 The lawless shrank back in fear of him, all who
practiced lawlessness were thrown into confusion, and deliverance
prospered by his hand. 7 He made many kings bitter, but he made
Jacob glad by his deeds, and his memory will be a blessing forever. 8
He went through the towns of Judah and wiped out the ungodly from
the land,[a] and so he turned wrath away from Israel. 9 His reputation
spread to the ends of the earth, and he gathered in those who were
dying.

10 Apollonius[b] then mustered Gentiles, along with a large force from
Samaria, to make war on Israel. 11 When Judas learned of it, he went
out to meet him, defeated him, and killed him. Many fell slain, and
the remainder ran away. 12 Then they stripped the dead. Judas kept
Apollonius's sword for himself, and he fought with it all his days.

13 Seron, commander of the Syrian army, heard that Judas had gathered a large band around him, an assembly of faithful men who were
ready for war. 14 He said, "I will make myself a name and gain glory
in the kingdom by fighting Judas and those with him, who treat the
king's command with contempt." 15 A strong army of the ungodly
once more marched up with him to help him take vengeance on the
Israelites. 16 As he neared the pass that climbs to Beth-horon,[c] Judas
came out against him with a handful of men. 17 But when they saw
the army coming against them, they asked Judas, "How can so few
of us fight against so great a horde? We are worn out, having had
nothing to eat all day." 18 Judas answered, "It is easy for many to be
delivered into the hands of a few. In the sight of Heaven[d] it makes
no difference whether it saves by many or by few. 19 Victory in battle
does not depend on the size of an army; strength comes from Heaven.
20 These men are coming at us full of insolence and lawlessness, to
wipe out us, our wives, and our children, and to plunder us. 21 But we
are fighting for our lives and our laws. 22 He himself will crush them
before our eyes. As for you, have no fear of them."
23 When he stopped speaking, he charged at them suddenly, and
Seron and his army were crushed before him. 24 They pursued them
down the slope of Beth-horon to the plain. Some eight hundred of
the enemy fell, while the rest escaped into Philistine country. 25 Then
Judas and his brothers began to be dreaded, and alarm fell on the
nations around them. 26 His fame reached the king, and every nation
talked of the battles Judas fought.
27 When King Antiochus heard these reports, he was enraged. He
sent orders and assembled all the forces of his kingdom, a very
powerful army. 28 He opened his treasury and paid his troops for a
year, ordering them to be prepared for any need. 29 Then he found
that the money in his treasury had run short and that the revenues
from the province were small, because of the strife and disaster he
had brought on the land by abolishing the laws that had been in force
from ancient times. 30 He was afraid that he would not have enough,
as had happened more than once, for the expenses and the gifts that
he used to hand out lavishly, more freely than the kings before him.[e] 31

Greatly perplexed, he determined to go to Persia, collect the revenues of those regions, and raise a large sum of money.
32 Lysias, a nobleman of the royal family, he left behind to manage the realm's affairs from the Euphrates River all the way to Egypt's frontier, 33 and to bring up his son Antiochus[f] until he returned. 34 To him he entrusted half the army and the elephants and gave instructions on all his plans, including what to do about the people living in Judea and Jerusalem: 35 Lysias was to send an army against them to break and destroy the strength of Israel and the remnant of Jerusalem, and blot out all memory of them from the place, 36 and settle foreigners throughout their territory and parcel out their land. 37 Then the king took the remaining half of his troops and set out from Antioch, his royal capital, in the year 147 (165 BC).[g] He crossed the river Euphrates and marched through the upper provinces.[h]
38 Lysias chose Ptolemy son of Dorymenes, together with Nicanor and Gorgias, powerful men among the Friends of the King, 39 and sent with them forty thousand foot soldiers and seven thousand horsemen to go into the land of Judah and ravage it, as the king had commanded.
40 So they set out with their whole army, and when they arrived they pitched camp near Emmaus[i] in the lowland. 41 When the traders of the region heard the report of them, they took a great deal of silver and gold, and chains,[j] and came to the camp to buy the Israelites as slaves. Forces from Syria and from the land of the Philistines joined them.
42 Judas and his brothers saw that their troubles had multiplied and that the armies were camped within their borders. They also learned what the king had ordered to be done to the people: total destruction.
43 So they said to one another, "Let us raise up our people and the holy place from their ruin."[k] 44 So the congregation assembled to make ready for war, and to pray and plead for mercy and pity.
45 Jerusalem stood empty, like a desert;
no child of hers went in or out.
The sanctuary was trampled underfoot,
foreigners held the fortress,
and it became a lodging for Gentiles.

Jacob lost its joy;
the flute and the harp went quiet.
46 They gathered and came to Mizpah,[l] opposite Jerusalem, because
Israel had formerly had a place of prayer at Mizpah. 47 That day they
fasted, put on sackcloth, sprinkled ashes on their heads, and tore their
clothes. 48 They unrolled the book of the law to inquire into matters
about which the Gentiles consulted the images of their idols.[m] 49 They
brought the priests' vestments, the firstfruits, and the tithes, and they
presented the Nazirites whose days were fulfilled.[n] 50 With loud voices
they cried to Heaven: "What are we to do with these people? Where
can we take them? 51 Your holy place has been trampled and profaned,
and your priests mourn in humiliation. 52 See, the Gentiles have
gathered against us to destroy us. You know what they are plotting
against us. 53 How can we stand before them unless you help us?" 54
Then the trumpets were blown, and a mighty cry went up.
55 After this Judas appointed officers over the people, commanders
of thousands, of hundreds, of fifties, and of tens. 56 Those who were
building houses, or were engaged to be married, or were planting
vineyards, or were afraid, he told to go back home, each of them,
as the law directs.[o] 57 Then the army moved out and camped south
of Emmaus. 58 Judas said, "Put on your armor and show courage. Be
ready at dawn to fight these Gentiles, who have gathered against us
to wipe out us and our holy place. 59 It is better for us to die in battle
than to look on while evils befall our nation and the holy place. 60 But
whatever Heaven wills, so it will do."

Notes

- a (3:8) Literally "from it," probably meaning the land of Judah.
- b (3:10) Probably the Apollonius of 1:29 (see the note there), governor of Samaria. Apollonius means "belonging to Apollo."
- c (3:16) The road from the coastal plain climbed into the hills through Lower and Upper Beth-horon, about 12 miles (19 km) northwest of Jerusalem. Beth-horon means "house of Horon," a Canaanite god.
- d (3:18) Here and often in 1 Maccabees, "Heaven" is a reverent way of referring to God.

- e (3:30) The Greek of this verse is difficult; literally "as once and twice, for the expenses and gifts which he used to give before with a generous hand, and he surpassed the kings before him."
- f (3:33) Antiochus V Eupator, then a boy of about nine.
- g (3:37) Greek: in the 147th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10), spring 165 to spring 164 BC.
- h (3:37) That is, the regions east of the Euphrates.
- i (3:40) Emmaus (later Nicopolis) lay at the edge of the hill country about 19 miles (31 km) west of Jerusalem.
- j (3:41) Swete's Greek text has "servants" (paidas); many editors read "fetters" (pedas), a change of one vowel that suits the context.
- k (3:43) Literally "Let us raise up the overthrow of our people and of the holy things," that is, reverse their ruin.
- l (3:46) Mizpah (Greek Massēpha), about 8 miles (13 km) north of Jerusalem, was an ancient place of assembly and prayer (Judges 20:1; 1 Samuel 7:5–6). Its name means "watchtower."
- m (3:48) The meaning is uncertain. The sense may be that they searched the law for the guidance that pagans sought from their idols, or that the Gentiles had painted images of their idols on the scrolls.
- n (3:49) Nazirites who had completed their vow had to offer sacrifices at the temple (Numbers 6:13–21), which was now impossible.
- o (3:56) Deuteronomy 20:5–8.

Chapter 4

1 Gorgias took a force of five thousand foot soldiers and a thousand
choice horsemen, and the detachment set off by night 2 to fall on
the Jewish camp and strike them unexpectedly. Men from the citadel
served as his guides. 3 Judas got word of it, and with his fighting men
he set out to attack the royal army at Emmaus 4 while its forces were
still dispersed away from the camp. 5 When Gorgias reached Judas's
camp by night, he found no one there. So he went looking for them
in the hills, telling himself, "These men are running away from us."
6 At daybreak Judas appeared in the plain with three thousand men,
though they lacked the armor and swords they would have wished
for. 7 They saw the Gentile camp, strong and fortified, with cavalry
ringing it, and these were men trained for war. 8 But Judas told the
men with him, "Do not fear their numbers, and do not be shaken
by their attack. 9 Think how our forefathers were rescued at the Red
Sea when Pharaoh chased after them with his army. 10 And now let

us cry out to Heaven to see whether he will favor us, remember the covenant with our ancestors, and shatter this army before us today. 11 Then every nation will know that there is someone who rescues and saves Israel."
12 The foreigners raised their eyes, saw them marching toward them, 13 they came out of their camp to fight. Judas's men sounded the trumpets 14 and the armies clashed. The Gentiles broke and ran into the plain, 15 and all the rear guard died by the sword. The Jews chased them as far as Gazara,[a] the plains of Idumea,[b] Azotus and Jamnia,[c] and around three thousand of the enemy were killed.
16 Returning from the chase, Judas and his troops came back, 17 and he said to the people, "Do not covet the spoils, because more fighting lies before us. 18 Gorgias and his army are in the hills near us. Stand firm now against our enemies and fight them; after that you may boldly take the plunder." 19 Judas had hardly finished speaking when a detachment appeared, peering down from the hills. 20 They saw that their army had been routed and that the camp was being burned, for the smoke they could see made plain what had happened. 21 Grasping this, they were terrified, and when they also saw Judas's army in the plain ready for battle, 22 they all fled into the land of the foreigners. 23 Then Judas went back to plunder the camp, and they seized a great deal of gold and silver, cloth dyed blue and sea purple,[d] and great riches. 24 On their return they sang hymns and praised Heaven: "For he is good; his mercy endures forever."[e] 25 So Israel had a great deliverance that day.
26 The foreigners who got away came to Lysias with a report of everything that had taken place. 27 When he heard it, he was confounded and disheartened, because things had not turned out for Israel as he intended, nor as the king had commanded him. 28 So in the following year he gathered sixty thousand chosen foot soldiers and five thousand horsemen to crush them. 29 They entered Idumea and encamped at Beth-zur,[f] and Judas confronted them with ten thousand men. 30 When he saw the strength of the army, he prayed, "Blessed are you, Savior of Israel, who broke the charge of the mighty warrior through your servant David, and who delivered the Philistine camp into the

hands of Jonathan, Saul's son, and his armor-bearer.[g] 31 Shut this army
in by the hands of Israel your people, and put them to shame for all
their soldiers and horsemen. 32 Make cowards of them; dissolve their
bold strength; make them reel in their downfall. 33 Cut them down
with the sword of those who love you, and may everyone who knows
your name sing your praise."
34 Then both sides engaged, and about five thousand of Lysias's army
fell; they fell before them in close combat. 35 Lysias saw that his ranks
were broken, and he saw how bold Judas's men were and how ready
to live or to die bravely, so he went back to Antioch. There he hired
mercenaries, planning to invade Judea again with a still bigger army.
36 Judas and his brothers then said, "Our enemies are defeated. Let
us go up now to purify the sanctuary and rededicate it." 37 Then all
the army gathered and climbed up to Mount Zion. 38 There they saw
the sanctuary desolate, the altar profaned, the gates burned, bushes
sprung up in the courts as in a thicket or on a mountainside, and the
priests' chambers torn down. 39 They tore their clothes and mourned
with loud lament; they sprinkled ashes on their heads 40 and fell face
down on the ground. They sounded the signal trumpets and cried out
to Heaven.
41 Judas then assigned men to attack those in the fortress while he
purified the sanctuary. 42 He chose blameless priests devoted to the
law, 43 and they cleansed the sanctuary and carried the stones that had
defiled it to an unclean place. 44 They deliberated about what to do
with the altar of burnt offering, which had been profaned. 45 A good
counsel came to them: they would pull it down, so that it should not
stand as a reproach to them, because the Gentiles had polluted it. So
they demolished the altar 46 and stored its stones on the temple mount
in a suitable place until a prophet should arise to decide what to do
with them. 47 Then they took uncut stones, as the law requires,[h] and
built a new altar on the model of the former one. 48 They built anew the
holy place and the inside of the house, and they sanctified the courts.
49 They made new holy vessels, and they brought the lampstand, the
altar of incense, and the table into the temple.[i] 50 They burned incense
upon the altar and kindled the lamps of the lampstand, and the temple

was filled with light. 51 They placed bread on the table and spread out
the curtains; and so all the work they had begun was complete.
52 Early on the twenty-fifth day of the ninth month, the month of
Kislev (in November–December), in the year 148 (164 BC),[j] 53 they
arose and made the sacrifice the law requires on the altar for burnt
offerings that they had newly made. 54 In the same season and on the
same day on which the Gentiles had defiled it, the altar was dedicated
anew, with songs, harps, lyres, and cymbals.[k] 55 All the people fell on
their faces and worshiped and praised Heaven, who had given them
success. 56 For eight days they celebrated the dedication of the altar.
They joyfully offered burnt offerings and sacrificed offerings of deliv-
erance and of praise.[l] 57 They adorned the temple's facade with crowns
of gold and little shields, renewed the gates and the chambers of the
priests, and hung doors on them. 58 The people's joy was immense,
and the shame the Gentiles had heaped on them was taken away. 59
Then Judas and his brothers and the whole assembly of Israel decreed
that the days of the altar's dedication should be observed with joy
and gladness at their season every year for eight days, beginning on
the twenty-fifth day of the month of Kislev.[m]
60 At that time they surrounded Mount Zion with high walls and
strong towers, so that the Gentiles could not come and trample it as
they had done before. 61 He posted troops there to keep it, and he
fortified Beth-zur as well,[n] giving the people a stronghold that faced
Idumea.

Notes

- a (4:15) Gazara is Gezer, about 20 miles (32 km) west-northwest of Jerusalem.
- b (4:15) So Swete's Greek text, though Idumea lies to the south; many editors read "Judea."
- c (4:15) Azotus is the old Philistine city of Ashdod, and Jamnia is Jabneh (Yavneh), both near the coast.
- d (4:23) Greek hyakinthos and porphyra thalassia, costly cloth colored with dyes made from sea snails.
- e (4:24) Psalm 118:1; 136:1.
- f (4:29) Beth-zur, about 18 miles (29 km) south of Jerusalem, on the border with Idumea. The name means "house of the rock."
- g (4:30) 1 Samuel 17 (David and Goliath) and 1 Samuel 14:1–23 (Jonathan and his armor-bearer).

- h (4:47) Exodus 20:25; Deuteronomy 27:5–6.
- i (4:49) Literally "the altar of burnt offerings and of incense"; the context indicates the incense altar. The table is the table for the sacred loaves.
- j (4:52) Greek: on the twenty-fifth of the ninth month, that is, the month of Chaseleu (Hebrew Kislev), in the 148th year of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:10), December 164 BC.
- k (4:54) The rededication took place three years to the day after the profanation (1:54, 59). 2 Maccabees 10:3 gives two years.
- l (4:56) Or "offerings of well-being"; Greek "sacrifice of salvation and of praise."
- m (4:59) This is the origin of Hanukkah (Hebrew "dedication"), the Feast of Dedication (compare John 10:22), still observed for eight days from the twenty-fifth of Kislev. 2 Maccabees 1:9, 18; 10:6–8 link the eight days to the Festival of Booths. The later custom of lighting lamps is not mentioned in 1 Maccabees; Josephus calls the feast "Lights" (Antiquities 12.325).
- n (4:61) Swete's Greek text has "to guard it" twice; the repetition may be a copying error.

Chapter 5

1 The surrounding nations learned that the altar had been rebuilt
and the sanctuary dedicated as before, and they grew furious. 2 They
resolved to wipe out the descendants of Jacob living among them, and
they began killing and destroying among the people. 3 Judas fought
the descendants of Esau in Idumea, at Akrabattene,[a] because they
were besieging Israel. He struck them a heavy blow, brought them
low, and seized their plunder. 4 He also remembered the wickedness
of the sons of Baean,[b] who had been a trap and a stumbling block to
the people by lying in ambush for them along the roads. 5 He shut
them up in their towers, laid siege to them, and devoted them to
destruction.[c] Then he set fire to her towers[d] and burned them with
everyone inside. 6 Next he crossed over against the Ammonites, where
he found a powerful band and many people, led by Timothy.[e] 7 He
fought battle after battle with them; they were shattered before him,
and he struck them down. 8 He also took Jazer[f] and its villages and
then returned to Judea.

9 Now the Gentiles in Gilead banded together against the Israelites
who lived in their territory, to destroy them. These fled to the strong-
hold of Dathema[g] 10 and sent a letter to Judas and his brothers that
said: "The Gentiles around us have joined forces against us to wipe

us out. 11 They are preparing to come and seize the stronghold where
we have taken refuge, and Timothy is at the head of their army. 12
So come now and rescue us from their grasp, for many of us have
already fallen. 13 All our kinsmen in the land of Tob[h] have been killed;
their wives, their children, and their goods have been carried off, and
about a thousand men have perished there."
14 The letter was still being read when other messengers arrived
from Galilee with their clothes torn and gave this report: 15 "From
Ptolemais,[i] Tyre, and Sidon, and from all Galilee of the Gentiles,[j] they
have mustered against us to annihilate us." 16 When Judas and the
people heard this news, a great assembly met to decide what to do
for their kinsmen who were in distress and under attack.[k] 17 Judas said
to his brother Simon, "Pick your men and go rescue your kinsmen in
Galilee. My brother Jonathan and I will go to Gilead." 18 He put Joseph
son of Zechariah and Azariah, leaders of the people, in charge of the
rest of the army in Judea, to protect it, 19 and gave them this order:
"Take charge of these people, but join no battle with the Gentiles
before our return." 20 Three thousand men were allotted to Simon for
the march into Galilee, and eight thousand to Judas for Gilead.
21 So Simon marched to Galilee and fought the Gentiles in many
battles, and they were defeated by him. 22 He pursued them to the gate
of Ptolemais. About three thousand Gentiles were killed, and he took
their plunder. 23 He then gathered the Jews of Galilee and Arbatta,[l]
along with their wives, children and everything they owned, and
brought them to Judea amid great celebration.
24 Judas Maccabeus, with Jonathan his brother, went over the Jordan
and marched three days into the desert. 25 There they came upon the
Nabateans,[m] who met them peaceably and told them everything that
had befallen their kinsmen in Gilead: 26 "Many of them are held captive
in Bozrah and Bosor, in Alema, Chaspho, Maked, and Carnaim,[n] all
large, fortified towns. 27 Others are shut up in the rest of the towns
of Gilead. The enemy plans to attack the strongholds tomorrow, take
them, and destroy all of them in a single day."
28 Judas and his army swiftly turned back by the desert road to Bosor.
He took the town, put every male to the sword, seized all its spoil,

and burned it to the ground. 29 From there he set off by night and
marched to the stronghold.[o] 30 At dawn they looked up, and there
was a countless host carrying ladders and siege engines to capture
the stronghold, and the attack was under way. 31 Judas saw that the
fighting had started, and that the outcry from the town, along with
trumpet blasts and loud shouts, was rising to heaven. 32 He told the
men of his army, "Fight today for our kinsmen!" 33 He came up behind
the enemy in three columns; they sounded the trumpets and cried out
in prayer. 34 When Timothy's army realized that it was Maccabeus,
they fled from him, and he dealt them a heavy defeat. That day about
eight thousand of them fell.
35 Then he turned aside to Alema,[p] attacked and captured it, killed
all its males, plundered it, and burned it. 36 Moving on from there,
he captured Chaspho, Maked, and Bosor, and the remaining towns
of Gilead.
37 After these events Timothy gathered another army and camped
opposite Raphon, on the far side of the stream.[q] 38 Judas sent scouts
to look over the camp, and they brought him word: "Every Gentile
nation round about has rallied to him, a very large force. 39 They
have also hired Arabs to help them, and they are camped across the
stream, ready to come and attack you." So Judas went to meet them.
40 As Judas and his army came near the stream, Timothy said to his
army's officers, "If he crosses to our side first, we will not be able to
hold him back, because he will surely beat us. 41 But if he loses his
nerve and camps on the other side of the river, we will cross over
to him and beat him." 42 When Judas reached the stream, he posted
the officers[r] of the people beside it and commanded them, "Let no
one pitch camp! Everyone must go into battle." 43 Then he crossed
over against them first, with the whole army following, and all the
Gentiles were crushed before him. They threw away their weapons
and fled to the sacred precinct at Carnaim. 44 But the Jews took the
town and burned the precinct with all who were in it. So Carnaim
was overthrown, and the enemy could no longer stand against Judas.
45 Then Judas gathered all the Israelites in Gilead, small and great,
with their wives, their children, and their goods, a huge throng, to

lead them home to Judah's land. 46 They came as far as Ephron,[s] a large
and strongly fortified town on the road. There was no way around
it to the right or the left; they had to go straight through it. 47 But
the townspeople shut them out and blocked the gates with stones. 48
Judas sent them a friendly message: "Let us pass through your land to
reach our own. Nobody will be harmed; on foot we will merely pass
along." But they refused to open to him. 49 So Judas had it proclaimed
throughout the army that each man should take up position where he
was. 50 The soldiers took up their positions, and he attacked the town
all that day and all night, until the town fell into his hands. 51 Every
male he put to the sword; the town he leveled; he stripped it, and he
passed through it over the bodies of the slain. 52 Then they crossed
the Jordan into the great plain facing Beth-shan.[t] 53 All along the way
Judas kept gathering the stragglers and encouraging the people until
he reached the land of Judah. 54 With joy and gladness they climbed
Mount Zion and offered burnt offerings, because they had returned
safely without losing a single man.

55 In the days when Judas and Jonathan were away in Gilead, and
Simon their brother in Galilee facing Ptolemais, 56 Joseph son of
Zechariah and Azariah, the army commanders, heard about their
brave deeds and the battles they had fought. 57 "Let us also make
a name for ourselves," they said. "Let us go and fight the Gentiles
around us." 58 So they gave orders to the troops under them and
marched against Jamnia. 59 Gorgias and his men marched out of the
town to give them battle. 60 Joseph and Azariah were routed and
chased as far as the borders of Judea; about two thousand of the
people of Israel fell that day. 61 The people suffered a great defeat
because they did not listen to Judas and his brothers but thought they
would do some brave deed. 62 These men were not of the line of those
by whose hand deliverance came to Israel.

63 But the warrior Judas and his brothers were greatly honored in the
sight of all Israel and of all the Gentiles wherever their name was
heard, 64 and people crowded around them to acclaim them.

65 Then Judas went out with his brothers and made war on Esau's de-
scendants in the southern country. He struck Hebron and its villages,

tore down its fortifications, and burned its towers all around. 66 Then he set out for the land of the Philistines and passed through Samaria.[u] 67 On that day some priests who wanted to prove their courage fell in battle, for they had gone out to fight without thinking it through. 68 Judas turned toward Azotus in the Philistine land. He demolished their altars, burned the carved images of their gods, looted the towns, and went back to Judea.

Notes

- a (5:3) Akrabattene was probably a district near the Scorpion Pass (Akrabbim, "scorpions") on Judea's southern border; Swete's text has "in Judea," which editors often correct to "in Idumea." The descendants of Esau are the Edomites, here the Idumeans.
- b (5:4) The sons of Baean are otherwise unknown; perhaps a tribe in Transjordan (compare Numbers 32:3, Beon).
- c (5:5) Greek anathematizō, the "devoting" of a defeated enemy to God by total destruction (Hebrew herem).
- d (5:5) The Greek has "her towers," perhaps referring to a town not named.
- e (5:6) Timothy means "honoring God." This Timothy is probably not the same as the one in 2 Maccabees 8:30–33; 10:24–37.
- f (5:8) Jazer was a town in Ammonite territory east of the Jordan.
- g (5:9) The site of Dathema is unknown.
- h (5:13) Greek "the region of Toubias," probably Tob in Transjordan (Judges 11:3–5), or possibly the land of the Tobiad family.
- i (5:15) Ptolemais is the coastal city of Acco.
- j (5:15) Isaiah 9:1.
- k (5:16) Swete's Greek has "attacked by him," perhaps meaning Timothy.
- l (5:23) Arbatta was probably a district in western Galilee or near the coastal plain; its location is uncertain.
- m (5:25) The Nabateans were an Arab people whose kingdom lay southeast of the Dead Sea, with its capital at Petra.
- n (5:26) These towns lay east of the Jordan in the region of the Hauran. Carnaim (Karnaim) is the old Ashteroth-karnaim, "Astarte of the two horns."
- o (5:29) Probably Dathema (5:9).
- p (5:35) Swete's Greek reads "Maapha," probably a copyist's slip for Alema (5:26).
- q (5:37) Greek cheimarrous, a stream that flows in the rainy season (a wadi). Raphon was in the Hauran.
- r (5:42) Or "the scribes"; the Greek grammateis can denote officers who kept the muster rolls (Deuteronomy 20:5).
- s (5:46) Ephron was east of the Jordan, perhaps about 9 miles (14 km) east of Beth-shan.

- t (5:52) Beth-shan (Scythopolis), in the Jordan valley south of the Sea of Galilee.
- u (5:66) So Swete's Greek text, though Samaria lies far to the north; many editors read "Marisa" (Mareshah), which lay between Hebron and the Philistine coast (compare 2 Maccabees 12:35).

Chapter 6

1 King Antiochus, meanwhile, was marching through the upper provinces. He heard that in Persia there was a city, Elymais,[a] renowned for its wealth in silver and gold, 2 and that its temple was very wealthy, containing gold armor,[b] breastplates and weapons left there by Alexander son of Philip, the Macedonian king who had been the first to rule the Greeks. 3 So he went and tried to capture the city and loot it, but he could not, because the citizens had learned of his plan. 4 They rose up to fight him, and he fled and left there in deep dismay to return to Babylon.

5 Then someone came to him in Persia with news that the armies sent into Judah's land had been put to flight; 6 that Lysias had gone at the head of a strong force but had been driven back before the Jews; that they had grown strong from the weapons, supplies, and abundant spoils they had taken from the armies they had cut down; 7 that they had demolished the abomination[c] he had built on the altar in Jerusalem; and that they had walled in the sanctuary with high walls, as it had been before, and had done the same to his town of Beth-zur. 8 When the king heard this news, he was stunned and deeply shaken. He took to his bed and fell ill from grief, because his plans had not worked out. 9 He lay there for many days, for his deep grief kept breaking out afresh, and he concluded that he was dying. 10 So he called all his Friends and told them, "Sleep has left my eyes, and my heart sinks under my cares. 11 I said to myself, 'To what distress I have come, and what a great flood of trouble I am in now! Yet I was kind and well loved while I held power.' 12 But now I remember the wrongs I did in Jerusalem. I seized all her silver and gold vessels, and I sent forces to wipe out the inhabitants of Judah without cause. 13 Now I know: for this cause these evils have found me out. Here I am, dying of bitter grief in a foreign land."

14 Then he summoned Philip, one of his Friends, and set him over all
his kingdom. 15 He gave him his crown, his robe, and his signet ring,
so that he might bring up his son Antiochus and train him to be king.
16 There King Antiochus died, in the year 149 (164 BC).[d] 17 When Lysias
learned that the king was dead, he set up as king the son, Antiochus,
whom he had brought up from boyhood, and named him Eupator.[e]
18 Meanwhile the men in the fortress were keeping Israel penned in
around the sanctuary. They constantly tried to do them harm and to
build up the Gentiles. 19 So Judas resolved to destroy them, and he
called all the people together to besiege them. 20 They gathered and
laid siege to the citadel in the year 150 (163/162 BC),[f] and he built siege
platforms and engines. 21 But some of the besieged escaped, and some
ungodly Israelites joined them. 22 They went to the king and said,
"How long will you put off judgment and avenging our kinsmen? 23
We were glad to serve your father, to walk by his word, and to keep
to his decrees. 24 For this reason our own people have turned against
us. They have killed as many of us as they could catch and plundered
our inheritances. 25 And they have not only struck at us; they have
attacked all the lands on their borders. 26 Look, today they have laid
siege to the citadel in Jerusalem to take it, and they have fortified
the sanctuary and Beth-zur. 27 Unless you move quickly to stop them,
they will go on to greater things, and you will have no power to hold
them back."
28 At this news the king flew into a rage. He called together all his
Friends, his army's commanders, and those in charge of the cavalry.[g]
29 Hired troops came to him from other kingdoms and from the islands
in the seas. 30 His army had a hundred thousand infantry, twenty
thousand cavalry, and thirty-two war elephants. 31 By way of Idumea
they came and pitched camp against Beth-zur. For many days they
attacked it and built siege engines, but the defenders sallied out,
burned the engines, and fought bravely.
32 Then Judas moved away from the citadel and camped at Beth-
zechariah,[h] opposite the king's camp. 33 Early in the morning the
king rose and drove his army at full speed along the road to Beth-
zechariah. His troops formed up for battle and sounded the trumpets.

34 They showed the elephants the juice[i] of grapes and mulberries to
rouse them for battle. 35 They distributed the elephants among the
battle lines. Beside each one they placed a thousand men wearing
chain mail and bronze helmets, and each animal was given five
hundred select cavalry. 36 These men were positioned ahead of time
wherever the elephant was; they moved wherever it moved, and
never left its side. 37 On each beast was a strong wooden tower, covered
over and fastened to it with special harness, and on each were four[j]
fighting men who fought from there, as well as its Indian driver. 38 The
rest of the cavalry he stationed on either flank of the army, to harass
the enemy and to shield the phalanxes. 39 When the sun shone on the
gold and bronze shields,[k] the hills gleamed with their light and blazed
like flaming torches. 40 Part of the king's army spread out over the
high hills and part over the low ground, and they advanced steadily
and in good order. 41 All who heard the noise of their multitude, the
tramp of the marching host, and the clash of arms trembled, for the
army was very large and strong.
42 Judas and his army advanced to battle, and six hundred men of the
king's army fell. 43 Eleazar, called Avaran,[l] saw that one of the beasts
was armored with royal armor and stood above all the rest, and he
judged that the king must be riding it. 44 So he gave himself up to
save his people and to gain an everlasting name. 45 Boldly he ran at it
into the middle of the phalanx, killing right and left, and they parted
before him on both sides. 46 He crept under the elephant and stabbed
it from below, killing it. It collapsed on top of him, and he died there.
47 When the Jews saw the strength of the royal army and the fury of
its troops, they withdrew from them.
48 The king's army went up to Jerusalem to meet them, and the king
encamped against Judea and Mount Zion. 49 He made peace with
the men of Beth-zur, and they left the town because they had no
food there to withstand a siege, since it was a sabbath year for the
land.[m] 50 So the king captured Beth-zur and left a garrison there to
keep it. 51 Then he besieged the sanctuary for many days. He set up
siege platforms and engines there, fire-throwers and stone-throwers,
and scorpions[n] for shooting arrows and slings. 52 The Jews also built

engines to counter theirs, and they fought for many days. 53 But there was no food in the storerooms, because it was the seventh year, and those who had taken refuge in Judea from the Gentiles had eaten up the last of the stores. 54 Only a few men were left in the sanctuary, because the famine had overwhelmed them; the rest scattered, each to his own home.

55 Then Lysias heard that Philip, whom King Antiochus while still alive had appointed to bring up his son Antiochus to be king, 56 had come back from Persia and Media, along with the soldiers who had gone with the king, and was trying to take over the government. 57 So he hastily gave orders to withdraw. He said to the king, to the commanders of the army, and to the troops, "We grow weaker every day, our food is running low, the place we are besieging is strong, and the affairs of the kingdom press upon us. 58 So let us now offer these men terms[o] and make peace with them and with their whole nation. 59 Let us agree that they may live by their own laws as they did before. It was over those laws, which we did away with, that they grew angry and did all this."

60 The proposal pleased the king and the commanders. He sent to the Jews to offer peace, and they accepted. 61 The king and the commanders swore an oath to them on these terms, and on that basis the Jews came out of the stronghold. 62 But when the king entered Mount Zion and saw how strong the place was, he went back on the oath he had sworn and ordered the surrounding wall pulled down. 63 Then he hurried off and went back to Antioch, where he found Philip master of the city. He fought against him and took the city by force.

Notes

- a (6:1) So Swete's Greek text, "in Elymais in Persia, a city"; Elymais was properly a region (Elam) at the head of the Persian Gulf. 2 Maccabees 9:2 names the city Persepolis.
- b (6:2) Or "golden shields"; Greek kalymmata, "coverings."
- c (6:7) Greek bdelygma; see note on 1:54.
- d (6:16) Greek: in the 149th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). Antiochus IV died late in 164 BC, which fits a year counted from autumn 312 BC. For other accounts of his death see 2 Maccabees 1:13–17; 9:1–29.
- e (6:17) Eupator means "of a noble father." Antiochus V was about nine years old.

- f (6:20) Greek: in the 150th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- g (6:28) Literally "those over the reins."
- h (6:32) Beth-zechariah lay about 6 miles (10 km) north of Beth-zur, on the road to Jerusalem.
- i (6:34) Literally "blood," a poetic term for red juice.
- j (6:37) Swete's Greek has "thirty-two," which cannot be right for a tower on an elephant; many editors read "four" (perhaps from a misread numeral or from v. 30), followed here.
- k (6:39) So some ancient witnesses; Swete's Greek text has only "golden shields."
- l (6:43) Swete's Greek reads "Eleazar Savaran"; see 2:5.
- m (6:49) The seventh year, when the land lay fallow (Leviticus 25:1–7).
- n (6:51) Scorpions were small catapults for arrows.
- o (6:58) Literally "give the right hand to these men."

Chapter 7

1 In the year 151 (162 BC)[a] Demetrius son of Seleucus[b] slipped away
from Rome, sailed with a few men to a town on the coast, and there
made himself king. 2 Just as he was going into his forefathers' royal
residence, the troops arrested Antiochus and Lysias to hand them
over to him. 3 When he was told of it, he said, "Do not let me look
upon their faces." 4 So the soldiers put them to death, and Demetrius
took his seat upon the throne of his kingdom.
5 Then all the lawless and ungodly men of Israel came to him, with
Alcimus[c] at their head, who wanted to be high priest. 6 They brought
charges against the people before the king: "Judas and his brothers
have destroyed all your Friends and driven us out of our land. 7 So
now send someone you trust. Let him go and see all the damage Judas
has done to us and to the king's land, and let him punish Judas and
everyone who helps him."
8 The king chose Bacchides,[d] one of the king's Friends, who governed
the province Beyond the River[e] and was a powerful man in the
kingdom, loyal to the king.
9 He sent him, along with the ungodly Alcimus, whom he confirmed
in the priesthood, and he charged him to take vengeance on the
Israelites.

10 They set out and entered Judah's land with a large force. Bacchides
sent envoys to Judas and his brothers with peaceful words, but
treachery was behind them.
11 They paid no attention to what these men said, because they saw
that they had arrived with a large force.
12 But a group of scribes did gather before Alcimus and Bacchides,
seeking fair terms.
13 Among the Israelites the Hasideans[f] were first to ask them for peace,
14 for they reasoned, "A priest of Aaron's line has come with the army;
he will do us no wrong."
15 Alcimus spoke peaceably to them and gave them his oath: "We will
seek no harm against you or your friends."
16 They believed him. But he seized sixty of them and killed them in
one day, as the word that he[g] wrote says:
17 "The flesh of your devoted ones they scattered,
and around Jerusalem they spilled their blood,
and none was there to bury them."[h]
18 Then fear and terror of them seized all the people, who said, "There
is no honesty or justice in them; they have broken the agreement and
the oath they swore."
19 Bacchides left Jerusalem and camped at Beth-zaith.[i] He had many of
the deserters who had come over to him arrested, along with certain
of the people, and he slaughtered them and threw them into the great
cistern. 20 He put the province in Alcimus's charge and left troops
with him to support him; then Bacchides went back to the king. 21
Alcimus struggled hard to hold the high priesthood, 22 and all who
were troubling their own people rallied to him. They gained control
of Judah's land and did great harm in Israel. 23 Judas saw all the evil
that Alcimus and his followers had done among the Israelites, worse
than the Gentiles had done. 24 So he went out through all the territory
of Judea round about and took vengeance on the men who had
deserted, and they were kept from going out into the countryside. 25
When Alcimus saw that Judas and his men had grown strong, and
knew that he could not withstand them, he went back to the king and
accused them of wicked crimes.

26 Then the king sent Nicanor,[j] one of his distinguished commanders,
a man who hated Israel and was its enemy, with orders to destroy
the people. 27 Nicanor arrived in Jerusalem with a large force and sent
a friendly but deceitful message to Judas and his brothers: 28 "There
should be no fighting between you and me. I will come to meet you
in peace, face to face, with a small escort." 29 So he came to Judas, and
the two men greeted each other in a friendly way; but the enemy
was waiting to seize Judas. 30 Word reached Judas that Nicanor had
come to him with treachery, so he grew wary of him and would not
meet him again. 31 When Nicanor saw that his plot was discovered,
he marched out to meet Judas in battle near Caphar-salama.[k] 32 About
five thousand of Nicanor's men fell, and the rest fled into the City
of David.
33 After this, Nicanor went up to Mount Zion. A few of the priests
came out of the sanctuary, together with some of the people's elders,
to greet him in a friendly way and to show him the burnt offering
being made on the king's behalf.
34 But he mocked them and laughed them to scorn; he defiled them[l]
and spoke arrogantly.
35 Furious, he swore, "If Judas and his army are not turned over to me
immediately, I will burn this house down on my safe return!" And he
left in a great fury.
36 The priests went in and stood before the altar and the temple,
weeping, and they said,
37 "You chose this house to be called by your name,
to be a house of prayer and supplication for your people.
38 Take vengeance on this man and his army,
and let them be killed by the sword.
Remember their blasphemies,
and do not let them survive."
39 Nicanor left Jerusalem and camped at Beth-horon, where an army
from Syria joined him. 40 Judas camped at Adasa[m] with three thousand
men. And Judas prayed: 41 "When the king's messengers blasphemed,[n]
your angel went forth and struck down a hundred eighty-five thou-
sand of them. 42 Crush this army before us in the same way today,

so that the rest may learn that he has spoken wickedly against your sanctuary. Judge him according to his wickedness."
43 The armies met in battle on the thirteenth day of the month Adar (in February–March),[o] and Nicanor's army was crushed; he himself was the first to fall in the battle. 44 When his troops saw that Nicanor had fallen, they flung down their weapons and fled. 45 The Jews pursued them a day's journey, from Adasa as far as Gazara,[p] sounding the signal trumpets behind them. 46 People came out of all the villages of Judea round about and outflanked them, turning them back on their pursuers, and all of them fell by the sword; not even one was left. 47 They took the spoil and the plunder. Nicanor's head they cut off, along with the right hand he had so proudly stretched out, and they brought them and displayed them just outside Jerusalem. 48 The people rejoiced greatly and kept that day as a day of great gladness. 49 They decreed that this day should be celebrated every year on the thirteenth of Adar.[q] 50 So the land of Judah had rest for a short time.

Notes

- a (7:1) Greek: in the 151st year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). Demetrius I reached Syria in the autumn of 162 BC.
- b (7:1) Demetrius I Soter, son of Seleucus IV, had been held as a hostage in Rome since his youth.
- c (7:5) Alcimus is a Greek name, "valiant"; his Hebrew name was Yakim (Eliakim, "God raises up"), according to Josephus.
- d (7:8) Bacchides (perhaps "son of Bacchus") was a senior Seleucid official.
- e (7:8) That is, west of the Euphrates (Syria and Palestine).
- f (7:13) The Hasideans (Hebrew hasidim, "the pious"); see 2:42.
- g (7:16) Or "the word that was written"; the Greek "he wrote" may refer to the psalmist.
- h (7:17) Psalm 79:2–3 (Septuagint 78:2–3).
- i (7:19) Beth-zaith, a village about 4 miles (6 km) north of Beth-zur; Swete's Greek spells it "Bezeth."
- j (7:26) Nicanor, "victorious."
- k (7:31) Caphar-salama ("village of peace"), of uncertain location, perhaps north-west of Jerusalem. Swete's Greek spells it "Charpharsarama."
- l (7:34) Perhaps by spitting on them or touching them, making them ritually unclean.
- m (7:40) Adasa was a village near Beth-horon, about 7 miles (11 km) north of Jerusalem.

- n (7:41) 2 Kings 18:17–19:35.
- o (7:43) Greek Adar, the twelfth month (Hebrew Adar). The battle took place in 161 BC. See also 2 Maccabees 15:36, which calls the date "the day before Mordecai's day."
- p (7:45) Gazara is Gezer, about 20 miles (32 km) west of Jerusalem.
- q (7:49) This was Nicanor's Day, a festival later observed by Jews for several centuries.

Chapter 8

1 Now Judas heard of the fame of the Romans: that they were very
mighty, that they looked with favor on all who sided with them, that
they established friendship with any who came to them, 2 and that
their strength was great. He was told of their wars and the brave
deeds they performed among the Gauls,[a] how they had conquered
them and made them pay tribute, 3 and what they had done in the
land of Spain to win control of the silver and gold mines there, 4 and
how, through their planning and patience, they had conquered the
whole region, though it was very far from them. He also heard of the
kings who had marched against them from the ends of the earth, and
how they had crushed them and dealt them a heavy blow, so that the
others paid them tribute every year. 5 Philip, and Perseus king of the
Kittim,[b] and others who rose up against them, they crushed in battle
and subdued. 6 Antiochus the Great,[c] king of Asia, who marched to
war against them with a hundred twenty elephants, cavalry, chariots,
and a vast army, was defeated by them. 7 They took him alive[d] and
required him and those who would reign after him to pay a heavy
tribute, to give hostages, and to surrender 8 the lands of India,[e]
Media, and Lydia, some of their finest provinces, which they took
from him and gave to King Eumenes.[f] 9 When the Greeks[g] planned to
come and destroy them, 10 the Romans heard of it and sent a single
general against them. They fought them, and many of the Greeks
were wounded and fell. The Romans took their wives and children
captive, looted them, seized their land, demolished their strongholds,
and enslaved them, as they are to this day. 11 The other kingdoms
and the islands, whoever at any time opposed them, they destroyed
and enslaved. 12 But with their friends and those who relied on them

they kept faith. They have subdued kings near and far, and all who
hear their name fear them. 13 Those whom they choose to help to a
throne do reign, and those whom they choose they depose; so they
have been raised very high. 14 For all that, none of them has ever worn
a crown or wrapped himself in purple to make a show of greatness.
15 They have built themselves a council chamber, and every day three
hundred twenty councilors[h] deliberate, constantly taking counsel for
the people, so that they may be well governed. 16 Each year they
entrust their government and the rule of all their land to one man,[i]
and all obey that one, and there is no envy or jealousy among them.
17 So Judas selected two men: Eupolemus, the son of John and
grandson of Accos,[j] and Jason, the son of Eleazar. He sent them to
Rome to secure friendship and an alliance with the Romans, 18 and
to lift the yoke from the Jews, for they saw that the kingdom of the
Greeks was reducing Israel to slavery. 19 After a very long journey
they reached Rome, went into the council chamber, and spoke these
words: 20 "Judas, who is called Maccabeus, together with his brothers
and the people of the Jews, has dispatched us to you to make a pact
of alliance and peace, and to be enrolled as your allies and friends." 21
The proposal pleased the Romans.
22 Here is a copy of the letter they engraved on tablets of bronze and
dispatched to Jerusalem, to be kept there by the Jews as a memorial
of the peace and the alliance: 23 "Good fortune to the Romans and to
the Jewish nation on sea and land forever, and may sword and enemy
be far from them. 24 But if war comes first on Rome or on any of
its allies throughout its dominion, 25 the Jewish nation shall fight as
their ally wholeheartedly, as the occasion may require of them. 26 To
those who make war on them the Jews shall not give or supply grain,
weapons, silver, or ships, as Rome has resolved; and they shall honor
these commitments without receiving anything. 27 In the same way, if
war comes first on the Jewish nation, the Romans shall gladly fight as
their allies, as the occasion may require of them. 28 To those who fight
alongside the enemy there shall be given no grain, weapons, silver, or
ships, as Rome has resolved; and they shall honor these commitments
without deceit. 29 Such are the terms by which the Romans have

bound themselves in treaty to the Jewish people. 30 If after this either party wishes to add or delete anything, they may do so by mutual agreement,[k] and whatever they add or delete shall be binding.
31 "As for the wrongs King Demetrius is doing to them, we have written to him this way: 'Why have you laid so heavy a yoke on the Jews, our friends and allies? 32 If they appeal to us again against you, we will uphold their cause and make war on you by sea and on land.'"

Notes

- a (8:2) The Greek Galatai may mean the Celts of northern Italy and Gaul, or the Galatians of Asia Minor.
- b (8:5) Philip V of Macedon was defeated by Rome in 197 BC, and his son Perseus in 168 BC. "Kittim" here means Macedonia (see 1:1).
- c (8:6) Antiochus III (reigned 223–187 BC), defeated by Rome at Magnesia in 190 BC.
- d (8:7) Antiochus III was not in fact taken captive; this is the writer's report of what Judas heard.
- e (8:8) "India" is hard to explain here; some suggest Ionia was meant. Media also seems out of place, since the treaty of Apamea concerned lands in Asia Minor.
- f (8:8) Eumenes II, king of Pergamum (197–159 BC).
- g (8:9) Probably the Achaean League, defeated by Rome in 146 BC; if so, the report reflects later events.
- h (8:15) The Roman Senate actually numbered about three hundred.
- i (8:16) In fact Rome elected two consuls each year.
- j (8:17) Eupolemus, "good at war," was perhaps the Jewish historian of that name. Accos (Hakkoz) was a priestly family (1 Chronicles 24:10; Ezra 2:61).
- k (8:30) Literally "by their choice."

Chapter 9

1 When Demetrius heard that Nicanor and his army had been killed in battle, he sent Bacchides and Alcimus into the land of Judah a second time, together with the right wing of his army.[a] 2 They took the road to Gilgal[b] and laid siege to Mesaloth in Arbela;[c] they captured it and took many lives. 3 In the first month of the year 152 (in March–April, 160 BC)[d] they pitched camp against Jerusalem. 4 Then they moved off and marched to Berea[e] with twenty thousand foot soldiers and two thousand horsemen.
5 Judas lay encamped at Elasa,[f] with three thousand picked men beside him. 6 When they saw how huge the enemy force was, they were

terrified. Many slipped away from the camp, until no more than eight hundred of them remained. 7 Judas saw his army melting away while the battle bore down on him. His heart sank, for he had no time to gather them again. 8 Faint as he was, he said to those who were left, "Up! Let us advance on our adversaries; perhaps we can still fight them." 9 But they tried to turn him from it: "We cannot. Let us save our own lives for now, and come back later with our kinsmen to fight them. We are too few." 10 Judas answered, "Far be it from me to do such a thing as run from them! If our hour has come, let us die bravely for our kinsmen and leave no stain on our honor."

11 Then the enemy army marched out of camp and took its stand to meet them. The cavalry was split into two divisions; slingers and archers went ahead of the army, and the front ranks were all men of valor. 12 Bacchides was on the right wing. The phalanx came on from both sides with trumpets sounding, and Judas's men too blew their trumpets. 13 The earth shook with the din of the armies, and the battle raged from morning until evening. 14 Judas saw that Bacchides and the strength of his army were on the right. All the stouthearted rallied to him, 15 and they broke the right wing and chased it as far as Mount Azotus.[g] 16 When those on the left wing saw that the right wing was broken, they wheeled around and came after Judas and his men from behind. 17 The fighting grew fierce, and many fell wounded on both sides. 18 Judas also fell, and the rest fled.

19 Jonathan and Simon took their brother Judas and buried him in their ancestors' tomb at Modein.

20 They wept for him, and all Israel made great lamentation for him. For many days they mourned, saying,

21 "How the mighty one is fallen,
the savior of Israel!"[h]

22 The rest of Judas's deeds, his wars, the brave exploits he performed, and his greatness have not been written down, for they were very many.

23 After Judas's death the lawless reappeared throughout Israel's territory, and all the doers of wrong sprang up. 24 In those days a very severe famine broke out, and the country went over to their side.[i] 25

Bacchides picked the ungodly and made them masters of the country.
26 They hunted down and tracked out Judas's friends and brought
them before Bacchides, who punished them and made sport of them.
27 Such affliction came on Israel as had not been seen since the day
when prophets were last seen among them.
28 Then all Judas's friends assembled and said to Jonathan, 29 "Since
the death of Judas your brother, no man like him has been left to
march out against our foes, against Bacchides, and against those of
our own nation who hate us. 30 So this day we have chosen you as ruler
and leader in his stead, to fight our battles." 31 At that time Jonathan
accepted the leadership and took the place of his brother Judas.
32 When Bacchides learned of it, he tried to kill him. 33 Jonathan,
his brother Simon, and all their followers learned of it and escaped
into the wilderness of Tekoa,[j] where they camped beside the pool of
Asphar. 34 Bacchides learned of this on the sabbath day, and he with
his whole army crossed the Jordan.[k]
35 Jonathan sent his brother John,[l] a leader of the company, to ask their
friends the Nabateans to keep their large store of baggage for them.
36 But the sons of Jambri[m] from Medeba came out, seized John and all
he had, and made off with it.
37 After these events Jonathan and Simon his brother were told: "A
great wedding is being held by the sons of Jambri. They are escorting
the bride, daughter of one of the great nobles of Canaan, from Nad-
abath with a grand procession."
38 Mindful of the blood of John their brother,[n] they went up and lay
hidden in the shelter of the mountain.
39 They looked out and saw a noisy crowd with much baggage. Out
came the bridegroom, with his friends and kinsmen, to greet the party
with drums and players and a great show of arms.
40 Then the Jews rose from their ambush and fell on them, killing them.
Many fell wounded; the survivors fled to the mountain, and the Jews
took all their goods.
41 So the wedding was turned to mourning,
and the sound of their music to a dirge.

42 Having fully avenged their brother's blood, they returned to the
marshes[o] of the Jordan.
43 When Bacchides heard of it, he came on the sabbath day with a large
force to the banks of the Jordan. 44 Jonathan said to his men, "Up now,
let us fight for our lives! Today is not like yesterday or the day before.
45 See, the fight faces us both before and behind; Jordan's water hems
us in on either hand, with marsh and thicket; there is nowhere to turn
aside. 46 Cry out to Heaven now, so that you may be rescued from our
enemies' hands." 47 When the battle was joined, Jonathan stretched
out his hand to strike Bacchides, but Bacchides drew back away from
him. 48 Then Jonathan and his men leaped into the Jordan and swam
over to the far bank, and the enemy made no crossing after them. 49
About a thousand of Bacchides's men fell that day.
50 Bacchides returned to Jerusalem and built fortified towns in Judea:
the stronghold at Jericho, and Emmaus, Beth-horon, Bethel, Timnath,
Pharathon,[p] and Tephon, with high walls, gates, and bars. 51 In them
he placed garrisons to harass Israel. 52 Beth-zur too he made strong,
and Gazara and the citadel, and stationed troops in them with stores
of food. 53 He took the sons of the country's leading men as hostages
and kept them under guard in the citadel at Jerusalem.
54 In the year 153, in the second month (in April–May, 159 BC),[q]
Alcimus ordered that the wall of the inner court of the sanctuary
be torn down. He was tearing down the work of the prophets,[r] and
he had begun the demolition, 55 It was then that Alcimus was struck
down, and his project came to a stop. He was paralyzed and his mouth
was shut, so that he could no longer speak a word or give instructions
about his household. 56 And Alcimus died at that time in great torment.
57 When Bacchides saw that Alcimus was dead, he went back to the
king, and the land of Judah was quiet for two years.
58 Then all the lawless plotted together: "Look, Jonathan and his men
are living in peace and confidence. Let us bring back Bacchides now,
and he will seize them all in a single night." 59 So they went and
consulted with him. 60 He set out to come with a large force and wrote
in secret to every ally he had in Judea, bidding them lay hands on
Jonathan and his men. This proved impossible, because their plan

became known. 61 Jonathan's men[s] seized about fifty of the men of the country who were ringleaders in this wickedness, and killed them.
62 Then Jonathan, with Simon and their men, withdrew to Beth-basi[t] in the wilderness. Its ruined parts he built up again and made it strong.
63 When Bacchides learned of it, he gathered his whole force and sent orders to those in Judea. 64 He came and camped against Beth-basi; for many days he fought against it and built siege engines. 65 But Jonathan left his brother Simon in the town and went out into the countryside, taking a few men with him.[u] 66 He struck down Odomera and his kinsmen and the sons of Phasiron in their encampment, and they[v] began to attack and to go up with their forces. 67 Then Simon and his men sallied out of the town and set fire to the siege engines.
68 They fought against Bacchides, and he was beaten by them. They pressed him hard, because his plan and his expedition had come to nothing. 69 He was enraged at the lawless men who had urged him to enter the country; many of them he put to death. Then he made up his mind to return to his own land.
70 When Jonathan learned of this, he sent envoys to him to make peace with him and to obtain the return of the captives. 71 Bacchides agreed and did as he asked. He swore to Jonathan that he would not seek to harm him as long as he lived. 72 He returned to him the captives he had taken earlier from Judah's land; then he turned and went back to his own land and never again entered their territory. 73 So the sword ceased from Israel. Jonathan settled at Michmash[w] and began to judge the people, and he wiped out the ungodly from Israel.

Notes

- a (9:1) Literally "the right horn," the elite wing of the army.
- b (9:2) Probably not the Gilgal near Jericho but a place in Galilee; some suggest "Galilee" was meant.
- c (9:2) Arbela in Galilee, west of the Sea of Galilee. Mesaloth may mean "steps" or "ascents."
- d (9:3) Greek: in the first month of the 152nd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). The first month is Nisan (March–April).
- e (9:4) Berea is probably Beeroth (modern al-Bireh), north of Jerusalem.
- f (9:5) Swete's Greek spells it "Alasa." Elasa lay near Beth-horon.

- g (9:15) Swete's Greek has "Mount Azotus"; the location is uncertain, as Azotus (Ashdod) lies on the coastal plain. Some suggest the slopes near Beth-horon.
- h (9:21) Compare 2 Samuel 1:19, 25, 27.
- i (9:24) Or "the land deserted with them."
- j (9:33) Tekoa, about 6 miles (10 km) south of Bethlehem.
- k (9:34) Verses 34 and 43 appear to be doublets in the Greek.
- l (9:35) John Gaddi (2:2). The Greek has simply "his brother"; the name appears in v. 36.
- m (9:36) Jambri, an Arab clan; the name is uncertain.
- n (9:38) Verse 36 reports only his capture; this verse assumes his death (see v. 42).
- o (9:42) Or "the mountain"; the Greek has "the mountain of the Jordan," perhaps a mistranslation of a Hebrew word for "jungle" or "thickets."
- p (9:50) So Swete's Greek "Thamnatha Pharathon," which may be one place or two; many translations print Timnath-pharathon.
- q (9:54) Greek: in the second month of the 153rd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). The second month is Iyyar (April–May).
- r (9:54) Probably Haggai and Zechariah, under whom the second temple was built (Ezra 5:1–2).
- s (9:61) The Greek has only "they seized."
- t (9:62) Beth-basi, near Tekoa.
- u (9:65) Swete's Greek has "and he went with a number," probably meaning a small band.
- v (9:66) Or "he." The Greek is unclear; it may mean that Jonathan's men began to strike the enemy.
- w (9:73) Michmash, about 7 miles (11 km) north of Jerusalem (1 Samuel 13–14).

Chapter 10

1 In the year 160 (152 BC)[a] Alexander Epiphanes, son of Antiochus,[b] came up and took Ptolemais. The people welcomed him, and he began to reign there. 2 Hearing of it, King Demetrius mustered a very large army and marched out to give him battle. 3 Demetrius also sent Jonathan a letter couched in peaceable terms, meant to raise him in honor. 4 "Let us move first," he reasoned, "and make peace with them before Jonathan makes peace with Alexander against us. 5 For he will remember every wrong we did to him, to his brothers, and to his nation." 6 So he gave Jonathan authority to raise troops and to equip them with arms as his ally, and he gave word that the hostages held in the citadel were to be released into his hands.

7 Jonathan went to Jerusalem and read the letter aloud to all the
people and to the men in the fortress. 8 These were struck with
great fear when they heard that the king had given him authority
to raise troops. 9 The men in the fortress handed over the hostages
to Jonathan, and he returned them to their parents. 10 Jonathan took
up residence in Jerusalem and set about building and restoring the
city. 11 He told those doing the work to rebuild the walls and to ring
Mount Zion with squared stones for defense, and so they did. 12 Then
the foreigners in the strongholds Bacchides had built took flight; 13
each of them abandoned his post and went back to his own country.
14 Only in Beth-zur did some remain of those who had forsaken the
law and the commandments, for it served them as a refuge.
15 King Alexander heard about all the promises Demetrius had sent to
Jonathan, and was told about the battles and bold deeds of Jonathan
and his brothers, and of the hardships they had suffered. 16 "Shall we
ever find another man like this?" he said. "Let us make him our friend
and ally at once." 17 So he wrote a letter and sent it to him in these
words: 18 "King Alexander to his brother Jonathan, greetings. 19 Word
has reached us about you, that you are a man of might and valor, well
fitted to be our friend. 20 So we appoint you this day high priest of
your nation; you are to bear the title Friend of the King, to take our
side, and to keep friendship with us." He also sent him a purple robe
and a golden crown.
21 So Jonathan put on the sacred vestments in the seventh month
(in September–October) of the year 160 (152 BC),[c] at the Festival of
Booths,[d] and he raised troops and laid in a great supply of arms.
22 When Demetrius heard of these things, he was vexed and said,
23 "What have we done, that Alexander has outrun us in winning the
friendship of the Jews to strengthen himself?
24 I too will write them words of encouragement, with offers of honors
and gifts, so that they may stand by me as helpers."
25 So he sent them this message:
"King Demetrius to the nation of the Jews, greetings.

[26] You have kept your covenant with us and remained in our friendship, and have not gone over to our enemies. We have heard of this and are glad.
[27] Now go on keeping faith with us, and we will repay you with good things for what you do for us.
[28] Many exemptions will we grant you, and gifts besides.
[29] "I now release you and free all the Jews from tribute, from the salt tax, and from the crown levies.[e] [30] Instead of a third of the grain and half the fruit of the trees that is due to me, I release them from this day on, so that they will no longer be collected from Judah's land, nor from the three districts joined to it out of Samaria and Galilee,[f] from now until the end of time. [31] Let Jerusalem and her territory be holy and free from tax, both tithes and tolls. [32] I give up also my authority over the citadel in Jerusalem, and I grant it to the high priest, to post there whatever men he himself may choose as its guard. [33] Every Jew carried captive out of Judah's land into any region of my realm I release as free, without ransom; and let all officials cancel the taxes on their livestock as well. [34] All festivals, sabbaths, new moons and appointed days, together with the three days before and the three days after each festival, will be days of exemption and release for every Jew in my kingdom. [35] No one shall have authority to exact payment from any of them or to trouble them in any matter.
[36] "Let Jews be enrolled in the king's forces, to the number of thirty thousand men, and let them receive pay as is due to all the king's forces. [37] Some of them shall be stationed in the king's great strongholds, and some appointed to positions of trust in the kingdom. Their officers and leaders shall be of their own number, and they shall live by their own laws, as the king has commanded in the land of Judah.
[38] The three districts added to Judea from the region of Samaria are to be annexed to Judea and reckoned under one ruler, obeying no other authority than the high priest. [39] Ptolemais and the land belonging to it I give as a gift to the holy place in Jerusalem, to defray what the sanctuary must spend. [40] I also grant each year about 375 pounds of silver[g] from the royal revenues out of the places that belong to me.
[41] And all the surplus that the officials did not pay over as in former

years they shall from now on give for the work on the temple. 42 Moreover, the 125 pounds of silver[h] that they used to take each year from the sanctuary's income are also released, because they belong to the priests who minister there. 43 Whoever takes refuge at the temple in Jerusalem or anywhere within its precincts, because he owes money to the king or for any other debt, shall be released, together with all his property in my kingdom. 44 For the rebuilding and restoring of the structures of the sanctuary, the cost shall be paid from the king's revenues. 45 And for rebuilding the walls of Jerusalem and fortifying it all around, the cost shall be paid from the king's revenues, as also for rebuilding the walls in Judea."

46 When Jonathan and the people heard these words, they put no faith in them and would not accept them, for they remembered the great evil Demetrius had done in Israel and how sorely he had oppressed them. 47 Alexander had their goodwill, for he was the one who had first opened talk of peace with them, and they remained his allies all his days.

48 King Alexander gathered large forces and encamped opposite Demetrius. 49 The two kings joined battle, and Demetrius's army fled. Alexander pursued him and overpowered them.[i] 50 He pressed the battle hard until the sun went down, and Demetrius fell that day.

51 Then Alexander sent envoys to Ptolemy king of Egypt[j] with this message: 52 "I have come back to my kingdom and taken the throne of my ancestors. I have secured my rule; I defeated Demetrius and gained control of our country. 53 I met him in battle; he was beaten by us, he and his host, and the throne of his realm is now ours. 54 Now let us establish friendship with each other. Give me your daughter in marriage; I will be joined to you by marriage and give you and her gifts worthy of you."

55 King Ptolemy answered, "It was a happy day when you came back to the land of your ancestors and sat on the throne of their kingdom! 56 What you have written I will now do. Come to Ptolemais, though, where we can meet face to face, and there I will give you my daughter, just as you ask."

57 So Ptolemy set out from Egypt with his daughter Cleopatra[k] and
came to Ptolemais in the year 162 (150 BC).[l] 58 King Alexander met
him there; Ptolemy gave him his daughter Cleopatra and held her
wedding at Ptolemais with great ceremony, as kings do.
59 Then a letter came from King Alexander inviting Jonathan to a
meeting. 60 Jonathan went to Ptolemais in splendor, where he met the
two kings. He gave silver, gold and many gifts to them and to their
Friends, and won their approval. 61 A band of scoundrels from Israel,
lawless men, gathered against him to bring charges against him, but
the king paid them no heed. 62 Instead the king gave orders that
Jonathan be stripped of his garments and clothed in purple, and so it
was done. 63 The king seated him at his side and said to his officers, "Go
with him into the heart of the city and make it known that none may
accuse him about anything or harass him for any reason." 64 When
his accusers saw the honor paid him, as was proclaimed, and saw
him clothed in purple, they all fled. 65 So the king honored him: he
entered his name among the First Friends and appointed him general
and governor of a province.[m] 66 And Jonathan went home to Jerusalem
in peace and with joy.
67 In the year 165 (147 BC)[n] Demetrius son of Demetrius[o] came from
Crete to the land of his ancestors. 68 When King Alexander heard of
it, he was greatly troubled and went back to Antioch. 69 Demetrius
appointed Apollonius, governor of Coelesyria,[p] who gathered a large
force and camped at Jamnia. He sent this message to Jonathan the
high priest:
70 "You alone are standing up against us, and I have become a laugh-
ingstock and a reproach because of you. Why do you lord it over us
in the hills? 71 If you trust in your forces, come down to us in the plain,
and let us test each other there, for I have with me the strength of the
cities. 72 Ask around and learn who I am and who our allies are. They
will tell you that you cannot hold your ground against us, because
your ancestors were routed twice in their own land.[q] 73 You will not
be able to resist such a force of cavalry as this on the plain, where
there is no stone or pebble and nowhere to run."

74 When Jonathan heard Apollonius's words, he was stirred to anger.
He chose out ten thousand men and marched from Jerusalem, and
Simon his brother came to join him with help. 75 He camped before
Joppa, but its people shut him out, because Apollonius had a garrison
in Joppa. So they attacked it, 76 and the people of the city, afraid,
opened the gates, and Jonathan took possession of Joppa.
77 When Apollonius heard this, he lined up three thousand cavalry
and a large army and marched toward Azotus as if only passing
through, while moving out onto the plain, because he had a great
deal of cavalry and trusted in it. 78 Jonathan pursued him to Azotus,
and the armies joined battle. 79 Now Apollonius had left a thousand
cavalry hidden behind them. 80 Jonathan learned that there was an
ambush behind him. The enemy encircled his army and from dawn
till late in the day rained arrows on his men. 81 But his men stood
firm, as Jonathan had ordered, and the enemy's horses grew tired. 82
Then Simon brought up his force and engaged the phalanx, for the
cavalry was exhausted. The enemy were crushed by him and fled. 83
The cavalry scattered over the plain; they fled to Azotus and went
into Beth-dagon, the temple of their idol,[r] to save themselves. 84 But
Jonathan burned Azotus and the towns around it and plundered
them. The temple of Dagon he burned with fire, and its sacred
precinct too.[s] 85 Those who fell by the sword, together with those
burned, numbered about eight thousand men. 86 From there Jonathan
set out and camped against Askalon, and its people came out to meet
him with great honor. 87 Then Jonathan returned to Jerusalem with
his men, laden with much spoil.
88 These reports moved King Alexander to heap further honors on
Jonathan. 89 He sent him a golden buckle, such as is customarily given
to the King's Kinsmen,[t] and he gave him Ekron and all its territory
as his possession.

Notes

- a (10:1) Greek: in the 160th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- b (10:1) Alexander Balas, who claimed to be a son of Antiochus IV Epiphanes.
- c (10:21) Greek: in the seventh month of the 160th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). The seventh month is Tishri (September–October).

- d (10:21) Greek skēnopēgia, "tent-pitching," the Festival of Booths (Tabernacles; Leviticus 23:33–43).
- e (10:29) Gifts of gold crowns, originally voluntary, had become a regular tax.
- f (10:30) The three districts were Aphairema, Lydda, and Rathamin (11:34). Swete's Greek here has "from Samaria and Galilee"; compare v. 38, which mentions only Samaria.
- g (10:40) Greek: fifteen thousand shekels of silver, about 6,000 oz (172 kg); weight standards varied.
- h (10:42) Greek: five thousand shekels of silver, about 2,000 oz (57 kg).
- i (10:49) Swete's Greek has "Alexander pursued him"; some editors, following the context and Josephus, read that Demetrius pursued Alexander's army. The translation follows Swete.
- j (10:51) Ptolemy VI Philometor (reigned 180–145 BC).
- k (10:57) Cleopatra Thea, later married in turn to Demetrius II and Antiochus VII.
- l (10:57) Greek: in the 162nd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- m (10:65) Greek meridarchēs, "ruler of a part"; that is, governor of a district.
- n (10:67) Greek: in the 165th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- o (10:67) Demetrius II Nicator, son of Demetrius I.
- p (10:69) Coelesyria, "hollow Syria," properly the Beqaa valley, but here used of the whole Seleucid province west of the Euphrates. Swete's Greek reads "Demetrius appointed Apollonius who was over Coelesyria"; some think Apollonius was Alexander's governor who went over to Demetrius.
- q (10:72) Perhaps a reference to the defeats of 1 Samuel 4 and 31.
- r (10:83) Beth-dagon, "house of Dagon," the Philistine god (1 Samuel 5:1–5).
- s (10:84) So Swete's Greek text, literally "and its temple"; some ancient witnesses read "and those who had fled into it."
- t (10:89) "Kinsmen" was the highest rank of honor at the Seleucid court.

Chapter 11

1 Then the king of Egypt massed forces as countless as the sand
along the seashore, along with many ships, and he schemed to seize
Alexander's kingdom by trickery and annex it to his own. 2 He set
out for Syria, claiming to come in peace, and the people of the towns
opened their gates and went out to meet him, since King Alexander
had ordered them to do so, because Ptolemy was his father-in-law.
3 But whenever Ptolemy entered a town, he left troops behind as a
garrison in it. 4 When he drew near Azotus, they showed him the
burned temple of Dagon, Azotus and its suburbs in ruins, the corpses
lying about, and the charred remains of those Jonathan had burned in
the battle, for they had piled them in heaps along his route. 5 They told

the king what Jonathan had done, hoping to bring blame on him, but the king kept silent. 6 Jonathan came with ceremony to meet the king at Joppa; they exchanged greetings, and both lodged there that night. 7 Jonathan accompanied the king as far as the river called Eleutherus[a] and then went back to Jerusalem.

8 So King Ptolemy made himself master of the coastal towns as far as Seleucia by the sea,[b] all the while plotting evil against Alexander. 9 He sent envoys to King Demetrius, saying, "Come, let us make a pact. I will give you my daughter, who is now Alexander's wife, and you shall reign over your father's kingdom. 10 It grieves me that I ever gave him my daughter, for he has sought my life." 11 He made these charges against him because he coveted his kingdom. 12 So he took his daughter away and gave her to Demetrius. He broke with Alexander, and their enmity came into the open.

13 Ptolemy then entered Antioch and put on the crown of Asia, so that he had two crowns on his head, that of Egypt and that of Asia. 14 At that time King Alexander was in Cilicia, because the people of that region were in revolt. 15 When Alexander heard of these events, he came to make war on him. Ptolemy marched out and met him with a strong force and routed him. 16 Alexander fled into Arabia to find shelter there, and King Ptolemy was exalted. 17 Zabdiel the Arab[c] cut off Alexander's head and sent it to Ptolemy. 18 Yet within three days King Ptolemy himself was dead, and the men he had posted in the strongholds were slain by those who lived there. 19 So Demetrius became king in the year 167 (145 BC).[d]

20 At that time Jonathan called together the men of Judea to storm the citadel in Jerusalem, and many engines of siege were set up against it. 21 But certain lawless men who hated their own nation went to the king and reported that Jonathan was besieging the citadel. 22 Angered by the news, he broke camp at once and came to Ptolemais. He wrote to Jonathan to lift the siege and to come with all speed to Ptolemais to confer with him. 23 When Jonathan heard this, he gave orders for the siege to go on. Choosing some of Israel's elders and some of the priests, he put his own life at risk. 24 With silver and gold, garments, and a wealth of other presents he came before the king at Ptolemais

and won his goodwill. 25 Some lawless men of his nation kept bringing
complaints against him, 26 but the king dealt with him as the kings
before him had done and raised him high in the sight of all his Friends.
27 He confirmed him in the high priesthood and in all the other honors
he had held before, and he made him one of his First Friends. 28 Then
Jonathan requested of the king that Judea, together with the three
districts and Samaria,[e] be made exempt from tribute, and he promised
him about eleven tons of silver.[f] 29 The king consented and wrote
Jonathan a letter about all these matters, as follows:
30 "King Demetrius to his brother Jonathan and to the nation of the
Jews, greetings. 31 We are sending you also a copy of the letter we
wrote about you to Lasthenes, our Kinsman, so that you may know
its contents: 32 'King Demetrius to Lasthenes his father,[g] greetings. 33
Toward the nation of the Jews, our friends, who keep faith in what
they owe us, we are resolved to act generously in return for their
goodwill toward us. 34 We confirm for them the land of Judea and
the three districts of Aphairema, Lydda and Rathamin;[h] these were
annexed to Judea from Samaria, together with all their lands. For
everyone who offers sacrifice in Jerusalem, this is given in place of the
royal payments the king used to collect from them each year from the
crops of the soil and the fruit of the trees. 35 As for our other revenues
from now on, from the tithes and tolls due to us, the salt pans, and
the crown levies due to us, all these we remit to them. 36 None of these
grants shall be revoked from now on for all time. 37 See to it, then, that
a copy of these terms is made and given to Jonathan, and set up on
the holy mountain in a fitting and conspicuous place.'"
38 King Demetrius saw that the land was peaceful before him and
that no one resisted him, so he sent all his troops home, each to his
own place, except for the foreign troops he had recruited from the
islands of the nations. As a result, all the troops who had served his
predecessors turned against him. 39 Now Trypho,[i] who had formerly
been one of Alexander's supporters, noticed how the whole army
was muttering against Demetrius. He went to Simalkue[j] the Arab,
who was bringing up Antiochus, Alexander's young son, 40 and kept
pressing him to hand the boy over, so that he might reign in his

father's place. He told him all that Demetrius had done and how his troops hated him, and he stayed there many days.
41 Meanwhile Jonathan sent a request to King Demetrius, asking him to withdraw the troops from the fortress in Jerusalem and from the strongholds, since they continued to attack Israel. 42 Demetrius sent this reply to Jonathan: "These things I will do for you and your people, and more: I will load you and your nation with honor once the moment is right. 43 So you will act rightly if you send me men to fight at my side, for all my troops have revolted." 44 So Jonathan sent three thousand strong soldiers to him at Antioch. When they reached the king, he was delighted by their coming.
45 Then the people of the city massed in the middle of the city, about a hundred twenty thousand of them, intending to kill the king. 46 The king took refuge in the palace, while the citizens seized the city's streets and began the fight. 47 So the king appealed to the Jews for help. They rallied to him at once, spread through the city, and killed about a hundred thousand people there that day. 48 They set fire to the city, seized much plunder that day, and rescued the king. 49 When the citizens saw that the Jews had mastered the city as they pleased, they lost heart and cried out to the king with supplication: 50 "Give us your right hand in peace, and let the Jews cease their war on us and on the city." 51 They threw down their weapons and made peace. The Jews gained great honor before the king and in the eyes of all in his kingdom, and they returned to Jerusalem with much plunder.
52 So King Demetrius sat on the throne of his kingdom, and the land was quiet before him. 53 But he broke every promise he had made. He turned against Jonathan, did not repay the kindnesses Jonathan had shown him, and treated him very harshly.
54 Some time later Trypho came back, bringing the little boy Antiochus,[k] who took the throne and was crowned. 55 All the troops whom Demetrius had cast off rallied to him, and they fought against Demetrius, who fled in defeat. 56 Trypho captured the elephants and took control of Antioch. 57 Young Antiochus then wrote to Jonathan: "I confirm you as high priest and appoint you over the four districts,[l] and you will be counted among the King's Friends." 58 He sent him

gold plate and table service, and gave him leave to drink from golden vessels, to be clothed in purple, and to wear a golden buckle. 59 His brother Simon he made governor from the Ladder of Tyre[m] to the borders of Egypt.

60 Then Jonathan set out and traveled through the province Beyond the River and its towns, and the whole Syrian army flocked to him in alliance. At Askalon the townspeople came out and received him with honor. 61 From there he went on to Gaza, but the people of Gaza barred him from entering. So he laid siege to it, set its suburbs on fire, and looted them. 62 The people of Gaza then begged Jonathan for mercy, and he made peace with them. He took their rulers' sons as hostages and sent them to Jerusalem. He then traveled through the region as far as Damascus.

63 News reached Jonathan that the generals of Demetrius were at Kedesh[n] in Galilee with a great force, aiming to oust him from his post. 64 So he marched against them, but Simon his brother he left behind in the land. 65 Simon camped against Beth-zur, attacked it for many days, and hemmed it in. 66 They asked him for terms, and he agreed. He drove them out of the town, took it over, and placed a garrison in it. 67 Jonathan and his army camped by the waters of Gennesaret,[o] and early in the morning they marched to the plain of Hazor.[p] 68 There, in the plain, the foreign army came against him. They had hidden men in the hills to fall on him, while their main body came straight at him. 69 Then the men in ambush rose from their places and joined battle, and all Jonathan's men fled. 70 Not a man was left, apart from Mattathias son of Absalom and Judas son of Chalphi, the army commanders. 71 Jonathan ripped his garments, threw earth on his head, and prayed. 72 Then he turned back to battle against the enemy, routed them, and they fled. 73 Seeing this, the men who had fled from him came back and chased the enemy along with him as far as Kedesh, to the enemy's camp, and there they encamped. 74 Of the foreigners about three thousand fell that day. Then Jonathan went back to Jerusalem.

Notes

- a (11:7) The Eleutherus (modern Nahr el-Kebir) formed the northern border of Coelesyria.
- b (11:8) Seleucia Pieria, the port of Antioch.
- c (11:17) Josephus calls him Zabeilos. The Greek Zabdiel means "my gift is God" (Hebrew).
- d (11:19) Greek: in the 167th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). Demetrius II became king in 145 BC.
- e (11:28) So Swete's Greek text; compare v. 34 and 10:30, 38, where the three districts are themselves taken from Samaria.
- f (11:28) Greek: three hundred talents, about 22,500 lb (10,200 kg). Weight standards varied.
- g (11:32) "Father" was a court title of honor.
- h (11:34) Aphairema (Ephraim, John 11:54), Lydda (Lod, Acts 9:32), and Rathamin (perhaps Ramathaim, 1 Samuel 1:1).
- i (11:39) Trypho, "luxury," was the nickname of Diodotus, a general.
- j (11:39) So Swete's Greek text; some ancient witnesses read "Imalkue."
- k (11:54) Antiochus VI Epiphanes Dionysus, about four years old.
- l (11:57) The three districts of v. 34 and perhaps the region around Akrabattene or Perea; uncertain.
- m (11:59) The Ladder of Tyre, a headland on the coast north of Ptolemais.
- n (11:63) Kedesh in Galilee, northwest of Lake Huleh (Joshua 20:7).
- o (11:67) The Sea of Galilee.
- p (11:67) Swete's Greek reads "Nasor," probably for Hazor, north of the Sea of Galilee.

Chapter 12

1 Seeing that the time was working in his favor, Jonathan chose men
and sent them to Rome to confirm and renew the friendship with
the Romans. 2 To the Spartans[a] and to other places too he sent letters
to the same effect. 3 So they journeyed to Rome, entered the Senate
chamber, and said, "Jonathan the high priest and the Jewish nation
have sent us to renew for them the friendship and alliance as it stood
before." 4 The Romans gave them letters to the authorities in each
place, asking them to send the envoys on their way to the land of
Judah in peace.

5 Here is a copy of what Jonathan wrote to the Spartans: 6 "Jonathan
the high priest, the council of elders of the nation, the priests, and
all the remaining Jewish people send greetings to the Spartans, their
brothers. 7 A letter was sent long ago to the high priest Onias by

Arius,[b] who was king among you at the time, saying that you are our
brothers, as the attached copy shows. 8 Onias received the envoy with
honor and accepted the letter, in which alliance and friendship were
plainly declared. 9 Now we, though we stand in no need of these, since
we take encouragement from the holy books in our hands, 10 have
ventured to send envoys to renew our brotherhood and friendship,
lest we grow strangers to you; for many years have passed since your
message came to us. 11 For our part, we always remember you without
fail, at our festivals and on the other proper days, in the sacrifices we
offer and in our prayers, as is right and fitting when remembering
brothers. 12 And we rejoice in your renown. 13 But as for us, many
troubles and many wars have hemmed us in, and the kings around
us have fought against us. 14 We did not wish to trouble you, nor
our other friends and allies, over these wars, 15 for we have the help
that comes from heaven to aid us, and we have been rescued from
our enemies, and our enemies have been brought low. 16 So we have
chosen Numenius son of Antiochus and Antipater son of Jason, and
have sent them to the Romans to renew our former friendship and
alliance with them. 17 We have instructed them to go to you also, to
greet you, and to deliver to you this letter of ours concerning the
renewal of our brotherhood. 18 And now you will do well to send us a
reply to this."
19 This is a copy of the letter that was sent to Onias: 20 "Arius king of
the Spartans to Onias the high priest, greetings. 21 A writing has come
to light about the Spartans and the Jews, showing that the two are
brothers, of Abraham's stock.[c] 22 Now that this is known to us, you
will do well to write us of how you fare. 23 We on our side write to you
that your livestock and your property are ours, and ours are yours.
We therefore command that our envoys report to you accordingly."
24 Now Jonathan heard that the commanders of Demetrius had come
back with a larger army than before to make war on him. 25 He
marched out of Jerusalem and confronted them in the region of
Hamath,[d] giving them no opportunity to set foot in his own country.
26 He sent spies into their camp, who came back and reported that
the enemy were drawn up to fall upon the Jews by night. 27 So when

the sun had set, Jonathan ordered his men to stay awake and under arms, ready for battle all night long, and he posted sentries around the camp. 28 When the enemy heard that Jonathan and his men were ready for battle, they became afraid, their courage failed, and they lit fires in their camp.[e] 29 Jonathan and his men, seeing the fires still alight, knew nothing of it till dawn. 30 Then Jonathan gave chase, but could not catch them, since they were already across the river Eleutherus. 31 So Jonathan turned aside against the Arabs called Zabadeans,[f] struck them down, and took their spoil. 32 Then he broke camp, came to Damascus, and marched through all that region. 33 Simon too set out and marched as far as Askalon and the nearby strongholds. He turned to Joppa and seized it before the enemy could, 34 for he had heard that its people were about to hand the stronghold over to the supporters of Demetrius. He stationed a garrison there to guard it.

35 When Jonathan came back, he called the elders of the people together and made plans with them to build strongholds in Judea, 36 to build the walls of Jerusalem higher, and to raise a tall wall between citadel and city, cutting the citadel off so that it would stand alone and its garrison could neither buy nor sell. 37 So they came together to build. A section of the wall along the eastern ravine had collapsed, and he repaired the part known as Chaphenatha.[g] 38 And Simon built Adida[h] in the Shephelah,[i] fortifying it and fitting it with gates and bars.

39 Then Trypho sought to become king of Asia, to put on the crown, and to lay hands on King Antiochus. 40 But he was afraid that Jonathan would not allow him and would make war on him. So he sought a way to seize and kill him, and he set out and came to Beth-shan.[j] 41 Jonathan went out to meet him with forty thousand picked men in battle array, and he too came to Beth-shan. 42 When Trypho saw that Jonathan had come with a large army, he was afraid to raise a hand against him. 43 Instead he welcomed him with honor, commended him to all his Friends, and gave him gifts. He ordered his Friends and his troops to obey Jonathan as they would himself. 44 Then he said to Jonathan, "Why have you put all these people to so much trouble, when there is no war between us? 45 Send them home now, and pick a

few men to stay with you. Come with me to Ptolemais, and I will turn it over to you, together with the other strongholds, the remaining troops and all the officials. Then I will turn around and go home; that is the reason I came." 46 Jonathan believed him and did what he said. He sent his troops away, and they returned to the land of Judah. 47 He kept with him three thousand men, of whom he left two thousand in Galilee, while a thousand went with him.

48 But as soon as Jonathan entered Ptolemais, the townspeople barred the gates and took him prisoner, and every man who had come in with him they put to the sword. 49 Trypho then sent troops and cavalry into Galilee and the Great Plain[k] to destroy all Jonathan's men. 50 These, believing that Jonathan had been seized and had perished along with his companions, encouraged one another and marched in close order, ready for battle. 51 Their pursuers, seeing that these men would sell their lives dearly, gave up the chase. 52 So all of them reached the land of Judah safely. They mourned for Jonathan and those with him, and they were in great fear; all Israel mourned deeply. 53 And all the surrounding nations tried to destroy them, saying, "They have no leader or helper. Let us attack them now and erase their memory from among human beings."

Notes

- a (12:2) The Spartans, citizens of Sparta (Lacedaemon) in southern Greece.
- b (12:7) Arius (Areus) I, king of Sparta 309–265 BC; Onias I was high priest about 320–290 BC.
- c (12:21) The tradition of kinship between Spartans and Jews is also found in 2 Maccabees 5:9 and Josephus (Antiquities 12.226).
- d (12:25) The region around Hamath on the Orontes, in Syria.
- e (12:28) The fires were meant to make it look as if the camp was still occupied while the enemy withdrew (vv. 29–30); some ancient witnesses add "and withdrew."
- f (12:31) An Arab tribe, perhaps near Zabdani northwest of Damascus.
- g (12:37) The meaning of Chaphenatha is uncertain; perhaps Aramaic for "the double one."
- h (12:38) Adida, Hebrew Hadid (Ezra 2:33), near Lydda.
- i (12:38) The Shephelah, "lowland," the foothills between the Judean hills and the coastal plain.

- j (12:40) Greek: Bethsan, Hebrew Beth-shan, “house of quiet” (Greek name Scythopolis).
- k (12:49) The Great Plain, the plain of Jezreel (Esdraelon).

Chapter 13

1 Simon heard that Trypho had raised a large army to invade the land
of Judah and lay it waste. 2 He saw how terrified the people were, so he
went up to Jerusalem and called them together. 3 He encouraged them,
saying, “You yourselves know what great things I and my brothers
and my father’s house have done for the laws and the sanctuary,
and what wars and hardships we have seen. 4 For this cause all my
brothers have perished for Israel’s sake, and I alone am left. 5 And
now, I would never spare my own life in any time of trouble, for I
am no better than my brothers. 6 Rather I will avenge my nation and
the sanctuary and our wives and children, for all the nations have
gathered out of hatred to crush us.” 7 Hearing these words, the people
took fresh heart, 8 and they answered with a loud shout, “You are
our leader in place of Judas and Jonathan your brother. 9 Fight our
battles, and whatever you tell us, we will do.” 10 So he assembled all
the fighting men and hurried to finish the walls of Jerusalem, and he
fortified it on every side. 11 He sent Jonathan son of Absalom to Joppa
with a sizable force; he drove out its inhabitants and remained there.
12 Then Trypho marched out of Ptolemais at the head of a great force
to enter Judah’s land, and Jonathan was with him as a prisoner. 13
Simon encamped at Adida, facing the plain. 14 When Trypho learned
that Simon had taken his brother Jonathan’s place and intended to
fight him, he sent messengers to Simon with this message: 15 “We are
holding your brother Jonathan because of silver he owed to the king’s
treasury for the posts he had. 16 Send now about four tons of silver[a]
and two of his sons as hostages, so that when he is released he will
not revolt against us, and we will release him.” 17 Simon knew that
they were speaking to him deceitfully, but he sent for the money and
the boys, lest he bring great hostility on himself from the people, 18
lest they say, “Jonathan died because Simon would not send the silver
and the boys.” 19 So he sent the boys and the silver, but Trypho broke
his word and did not release Jonathan.

20 After this, Trypho came to invade the land and ruin it. He took the
road around by Adora,[b] but wherever he went, Simon and his army
kept pace alongside him. 21 The citadel garrison, for their part, sent
messenger after messenger to Trypho, pressing him to reach them
through the wilderness and get food to them. 22 So Trypho made ready
all his cavalry to go, but that night there was a very heavy snowfall,
and because of the snow he did not go. He set out and went into
Gilead. 23 When he drew near Baskama,[c] he killed Jonathan, and he
was buried there. 24 Then Trypho turned back and went to his own
land.
25 Simon sent for the bones of his brother Jonathan and buried him at
Modein, the town of their ancestors. 26 All Israel lamented him with
great lamentation and mourned for him many days. 27 Over the tomb
of his father and his brothers Simon built a monument, high enough
to be seen, with polished stone at back and front. 28 He erected seven
pyramids, one opposite another, for his father and mother and four
brothers. 29 For the pyramids he designed an elaborate arrangement:
he put up tall columns around them, and on the columns he set suits
of armor as an eternal memorial, and next to the armor he carved
ships, so that everyone sailing the sea could see them. 30 This tomb
that he built at Modein remains to this day.
31 Trypho dealt treacherously with the young King Antiochus; he
killed him 32 and reigned in his place. He put on the crown of Asia
and brought great disaster on the land. 33 But Simon built up the
strongholds of Judea, girding them with high towers and great walls,
with gates and bars, and he stored food in the strongholds. 34 Simon
also chose men and sent them to King Demetrius, asking him to grant
the land relief, for all that Trypho did was plunder. 35 King Demetrius
answered him in line with this request, writing him the following
letter:
36 "King Demetrius to Simon, high priest and Friend of kings, and
to the elders and nation of the Jews, greetings. 37 We have received
the golden crown, and also the palm branch[d] that you sent. We are
prepared to establish a lasting peace with you, and to instruct our
officials to give you tax exemptions. 38 All the agreements we have

made with you stand, and the strongholds that you have built shall be yours. 39 We pardon any errors and offenses committed up to this day, and we cancel the crown tax that you owed; and whatever other tax was collected in Jerusalem shall be collected no longer. 40 Any of you who are qualified to join our bodyguard, let them be enrolled, and let there be peace between us."

41 In the year 170 (142 BC)[e] the yoke of the Gentiles was lifted from Israel, 42 and the people started writing in their documents and contracts, "In the first year of Simon, great high priest, commander, and leader of the Jews."

43 In those days Simon[f] camped against Gaza[g] and surrounded it with troops. He built a siege tower, brought it up to the city, battered one of the towers, and captured it. 44 The men in the siege tower leaped out into the city, and a great uproar arose in the city. 45 The townspeople, wives and children with them, climbed onto the wall, rending their garments, and shouted aloud, begging Simon to make peace with them. 46 "Do not treat us as our wicked deeds deserve," they said, "but as your mercy allows." 47 So Simon made terms with them and did not attack them. He drove them out of the city and purified the houses that held idols, and then he entered it singing hymns of praise. 48 He cast out all uncleanness from it and settled in it men who observe the law. He strengthened its fortifications and built a residence there for himself.

49 The garrison of the citadel in Jerusalem, cut off from going out to the countryside to buy and sell, suffered severe hunger, and many of them died of starvation. 50 They begged Simon for peace, and he agreed. He drove them out from there and cleansed the fortress of its defilement. 51 On the twenty-third day of the second month (in April–May) in the year 171 (141 BC),[h] the Jews went into it with praise and palm branches, with harps, cymbals and lyres, with hymns and songs, because a great enemy had been defeated and removed from Israel. 52 He made it a law that this day be kept with gladness year by year. The temple mount beside the citadel he made still stronger, and there he made his home, he and his men. 53 When Simon saw that his son

John[i] had grown to manhood, he appointed him commander of all the forces, and John lived at Gazara.

Notes

- a (13:16) Greek: one hundred talents, about 7,500 lb (3,400 kg). Weight standards varied.
- b (13:20) Adora (Adoraim, 2 Chronicles 11:9), southwest of Hebron.
- c (13:23) Location unknown; probably northeast of the Sea of Galilee.
- d (13:37) Greek baïn, a palm branch, perhaps of gold, given as a token of homage.
- e (13:41) Greek: in the 170th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- f (13:43) Greek: he; Simon is meant.
- g (13:43) So Swete's Greek text; many editors read Gazara (Gezer), following v. 53, 14:7, and Josephus, since Gaza lay outside Simon's territory.
- h (13:51) Greek: the twenty-third of the second month of the 171st year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). The second month is Iyyar (April–May).
- i (13:53) John Hyrcanus, ruler of Judea 134–104 BC.

Chapter 14

1 In the year 172 (140 BC)[a] King Demetrius assembled his forces
and marched into Media to gain reinforcements for his war against
Trypho. 2 Arsaces,[b] king of Persia and Media, learned that Demetrius
had entered his territory, and he dispatched one of his commanders
to take Demetrius alive. 3 The commander went out, defeated
Demetrius's army, took him prisoner, and brought him to Arsaces,
who had him placed under guard.

4 The land was at peace throughout Simon's days.
He worked for his nation's good;
his rule and his glory delighted them all his life.
5 As the crown of all his honors, he captured Joppa as a harbor
and made a gateway to the islands of the sea.
6 He enlarged the frontiers of his people
and held the land firmly in his grip.
7 He gathered in a host of captives;
he became master of Gazara, Beth-zur, and the citadel,
and removed its uncleanness from it,
and there was none to withstand him.

8 In peace they worked their fields;
the soil yielded its harvest,
and the orchards of the plain bore fruit.
9 Old men sat in the streets,
all talking together of good things,
and the young men put on splendid garments and the dress of war.
10 He supplied the towns with food
and furnished them with means of defense,
until the fame of his glory was spoken of to the ends of the earth.
11 He established peace in the land,
and Israel rejoiced with great joy.
12 Each sat under his own vine and his own fig tree,[c]
and there was none to make them afraid.
13 None remained in the land to wage war on them;
in those days kings were broken.
14 He gave strength to all the lowly of his people;
he searched out the law
and did away with every lawless and wicked person.
15 He brought splendor to the holy place
and increased its sacred furnishings.

16 News of Jonathan's death reached Rome and even Sparta, and there was deep sorrow. 17 But once they learned that Simon his brother had taken his place as high priest and was ruling over the country and the towns in it, 18 they wrote to him on bronze tablets, to renew the friendship and alliance that they had made with his brothers Judas and Jonathan. 19 And these were read before the assembly in Jerusalem.

20 This is a copy of the letter sent by the Spartans:

"From the rulers and the city of the Spartans, greetings to Simon the high priest, to the elders and priests, and to the rest of the Jewish people, our brothers.

21 The envoys sent to our people have told us of your glory and honor, and we were glad at their coming.

22 Their report we have entered among the people's resolutions, in
these words: 'Numenius son of Antiochus and Antipater son of Jason,
Jewish envoys, have come before us to renew their friendship with us.
23 Our people resolved to welcome these men with honor and to lay
up a copy of their words in the public records, as a memorial for the
Spartan people.' And they have written a copy of this to Simon the
high priest."
24 After this Simon sent Numenius to Rome with a great golden
shield weighing about 1,250 pounds,[d] to confirm the alliance with the
Romans.
25 Hearing of these events, the people asked, "What thanks can we give
to Simon and his sons? 26 For he and his brothers and his father's house
have stood firm; they have fought and driven off Israel's enemies and
secured its freedom." So they inscribed this on bronze tablets and set
them on a pillar on Mount Zion.
27 What follows is a copy of the inscription:

"In the year 172 (140 BC),[e] on the eighteenth day of Elul (in
August–September), the third year of Simon the great high priest,
28 at Asaramel,[f] in the great assembly of the priests and the people,
the nation's rulers, and the elders of the land, this was made known
to us:
29 'Since wars have often arisen in the country, Simon son of Mat-
tathias, a priest of the line of Joarib,[g] together with his brothers, put
themselves in peril and stood against their nation's foes, to keep their
sanctuary and the law standing; and they won high renown for their
people.
30 Jonathan rallied the nation and became their high priest, and then
he was gathered to his people.
31 When their enemies resolved to invade their country and lay it
waste, and to lay hands on their sanctuary,
32 then Simon rose up and fought for his nation. He spent much of his
own wealth; he armed the soldiers of his nation and paid their wages.
33 Judea's towns he fortified, and Beth-zur too, on Judea's frontier,
which had once been the enemy's arsenal, and there he posted Jews
as a garrison.

34 He fortified Joppa by the sea, and Gazara on the borders of Azotus,
where the enemy had formerly lived. There he planted Jewish settlers
and furnished the towns with all they required for their rebuilding.
35 The people saw how faithful Simon was and what glory he meant
to bring his nation, and they chose him as their leader and high priest
for all that he had done, and for the uprightness and good faith he had
kept toward his people. He sought in every way to exalt his people.
36 In his days things prospered in his hands, so that the Gentiles were
driven out of the country, and likewise the men in the City of David at
Jerusalem, who had made a citadel for themselves and would go out
from it to pollute the area around the sanctuary, doing great damage
to its purity.
37 He settled Jews in it and fortified it to protect the country and the
city, and he made the walls of Jerusalem higher.
38 For these reasons King Demetrius confirmed his high priesthood,
39 made him one of his Friends, and paid him high honors.
40 For he had heard that the Romans called the Jews friends, allies
and brothers, and that they had given Simon's envoys an honorable
welcome.
41 The Jews and the priests have been pleased to have Simon as their
leader and high priest for all time, till a prophet worthy of trust should
appear,[h]
42 and that he should be commander over them and take charge of the
sanctuary, appointing officials over its tasks and over the country, the
weapons, and the strongholds;
43 that he should take charge of the sanctuary, and be obeyed by all;
that all contracts in the country should be written in his name; and
that he should be clothed in purple and wear gold.
44 No one among the people or the priests will be allowed to overturn
any of these decisions, to contradict what he says, to call a gathering
in the country without him, or to dress in purple or wear a gold clasp.
45 Anyone who goes against these terms or sets any of them aside shall
be held guilty.'
46 The whole people consented to let Simon act on these terms.

47 So Simon accepted, and agreed to serve as high priest and as general and ethnarch[i] of the Jews and the priests, and to stand at the head of all."

48 They gave orders that this inscription be placed on bronze tablets and set up in the precincts of the sanctuary in a prominent place, 49 and that copies of it be deposited in the treasury, so that Simon and his sons might have them.

Notes

- a (14:1) Greek: in the 172nd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- b (14:2) Arsaces, the royal title of the Parthian kings; here Mithradates I (about 171–138 BC).
- c (14:12) Compare Micah 4:4 and 1 Kings 4:25.
- d (14:24) Greek: a thousand minas, about 1,250 lb (570 kg); the mina was one sixtieth of a talent, and standards varied.
- e (14:27) Greek: the eighteenth of Elul, of the 172nd year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). Elul is the sixth month (August–September).
- f (14:28) So Swete's Greek text (Saramel in some ancient witnesses). The meaning is uncertain; perhaps Hebrew for "court of the people of God," or a title, "prince of the people of God."
- g (14:29) Joarib (Jehoiarib), the first of the priestly divisions (1 Chronicles 24:7).
- h (14:41) Compare 4:46.
- i (14:47) Ethnarch, "ruler of the nation."

Chapter 15

1 A letter from Antiochus, the son of King Demetrius,[a] was sent from the islands of the sea to Simon, who was priest and ethnarch of the Jews, and to the whole nation.

2 Its contents were as follows:

"King Antiochus to Simon the great priest and ethnarch, and to the nation of the Jews, greetings.

3 Whereas certain pestilent men have made themselves masters of my fathers' kingdom, and it is my purpose to reclaim that kingdom and set it back as it once stood, I have recruited a host of troops and fitted out warships.

4 I mean to land in the country so that I may go after those who have ruined our country and laid waste many towns in my kingdom.

5 So now I confirm for you all the tax cancellations granted by the
kings before me, and any other exemptions they gave you.
6 You may strike coins of your own, to be the currency of your land.[b]
7 Jerusalem and the sanctuary shall be free. All the weapons you have
made and the strongholds you have built and now hold shall remain
yours.
8 Every debt you owe to the royal treasury, and any royal dues that
may arise hereafter, are canceled for you from now on and for all time.
9 And when we have regained our kingdom, we will bestow great
honor on you, your nation, and the temple, so that your glory will be
made plain in all the earth."
10 In the year 174 (138 BC)[c] Antiochus marched into the land of
his ancestors. The troops came over to him in a body, until only a
few remained on Trypho's side. 11 With King Antiochus in pursuit,
Trypho fled and reached Dor[d] on the seacoast; 12 for he knew that
troubles had piled up against him and that his troops had deserted
him. 13 Antiochus pitched camp against Dor with a hundred twenty
thousand fighting men and eight thousand horsemen. 14 He encircled
the town, and the ships closed in from the sea. So he pressed the town
hard by land and sea and let no one go out or come in.
15 Then Numenius and his companions arrived from Rome, bringing
letters to the kings and countries, in which was written the following:
16 "Lucius,[e] consul of the Romans, to King Ptolemy,[f] greetings. 17 The
Jewish envoys have come to us as our friends and allies to renew
the old friendship and alliance. Simon the high priest and the Jewish
people sent them, 18 and they have brought a gold shield weighing
about 6,250 pounds.[g] 19 We have therefore decided to write to the kings
and countries, so that they will not try to harm the Jews, attack them
or their towns or their land, or aid anyone who fights against them.
20 It is our decision to receive the shield at their hands. 21 So if any
troublemakers have fled from their land and found shelter with you,
hand them over to Simon the high priest, so that he can punish them
under their own law."
22 Letters to the same effect went to King Demetrius,[h] to Attalus,[i]
Ariarathes,[j] and Arsaces, 23 and to all the countries: to Sampsames,[k] to

the Spartans, and to Delos, Myndos, Sicyon, Caria, Samos, Pamphylia, Lycia, Halicarnassus, Cos, Side, Arados, Rhodes, Phaselis, Gortyn, Cnidus, Cyprus, and Cyrene.[l] 24 And a copy of the whole was written out for Simon the high priest.

25 King Antiochus besieged Dor in its outskirts,[m] continually throwing his forces against it and building siege engines; and he shut Trypho in, so that no one could go out or in. 26 Simon sent him two thousand picked men to fight on his side, along with silver and gold and a good deal of equipment. 27 But Antiochus would not accept them. He broke every agreement he had made with Simon before and turned against him. 28 He sent Athenobius, one of his Friends, to confer with him, saying, "You hold Joppa and Gazara and the citadel in Jerusalem, which are towns of my kingdom. 29 You have laid waste their territory, done great harm to the land, and made yourselves masters of many places in my kingdom. 30 Now then, hand over the towns you have seized, and the tribute of the places you have taken outside the borders of Judea; 31 or else give me in their place about nineteen tons of silver,[n] and for the destruction you have caused and for the tribute of the towns, another nineteen tons. Otherwise we will come and make war on you."

32 So Athenobius, the king's Friend, came to Jerusalem. When he saw the splendor of Simon, his sideboard laden with gold and silver vessels, and his great retinue, he was astounded. He gave him the king's message. 33 Simon answered him, "We have neither taken foreign land nor seized anything that belongs to others, but only the inheritance of our ancestors, which our enemies at one time unjustly took. 34 Now that we have the opportunity, we are holding firmly to the inheritance of our ancestors. 35 As for Joppa and Gazara, which you demand, those towns were doing great harm among our people and in our land; for them we will give about four tons of silver."[o] Athenobius did not answer him a word, 36 but returned in a rage to the king and reported to him these words, the splendor of Simon, and all he had seen. And the king was furious.

37 Meanwhile Trypho boarded a ship and fled to Orthosia.[p] 38 Then the king made Cendebeus commander-in-chief of the coastal region and

gave him troops of infantry and cavalry. 39 He ordered him to encamp facing Judea, to rebuild Kedron[q] and strengthen the towns,[r] and to wage war on the people, while the king pursued Trypho. 40 So Cendebeus came to Jamnia and began to provoke the people, invading Judea, taking the people captive, and killing them. 41 At Kedron, which he rebuilt, he stationed cavalry and soldiers to go out and patrol the roads of Judea, as the king had commanded him.

Notes

- a (15:1) Antiochus VII Sidetes (reigned 138–129 BC), younger brother of Demetrius II.
- b (15:6) No coins of Simon are known; the first Hasmonean coins were struck later, perhaps under John Hyrcanus.
- c (15:10) Greek: in the 174th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10).
- d (15:11) Dor, a coastal town south of Mount Carmel.
- e (15:16) Perhaps Lucius Caecilius Metellus, consul in 142 BC, or Lucius Calpurnius Piso, consul in 139 BC; uncertain.
- f (15:16) Ptolemy VIII Euergetes II of Egypt.
- g (15:18) Greek: five thousand minas, about 6,250 lb (2,850 kg); compare 14:24, which gives a thousand minas.
- h (15:22) Demetrius II, then a captive in Parthia (14:3).
- i (15:22) Attalus II of Pergamum.
- j (15:22) Ariarathes V of Cappadocia.
- k (15:23) Sampsames, perhaps Samsun on the Black Sea; uncertain.
- l (15:23) Cities and regions of Greece, Asia Minor, the islands, and North Africa.
- m (15:25) Greek: in the second; the meaning is uncertain. It may mean "on the second day" or "a second time."
- n (15:31) Greek: five hundred talents of silver, about 37,500 lb (17,000 kg); likewise in the next clause. Weight standards varied.
- o (15:35) Greek: one hundred talents, about 7,500 lb (3,400 kg).
- p (15:37) Orthosia, a port on the Phoenician coast north of Tripolis.
- q (15:39) Kedron, probably modern Qatra, near Jamnia.
- r (15:39) So Swete's Greek text; some ancient witnesses read "its gates."

Chapter 16

1 Coming up from Gazara, John reported to Simon his father all that
Cendebeus was about. 2 Simon summoned his two eldest sons, Judas
and John, and said to them, "From our youth until this day, I and my
brothers and my father's house have fought Israel's wars, and time
and again we have succeeded in rescuing Israel. 3 But now I have

grown old, while you, by Heaven's mercy, are of full age. Stand in
my place and my brother's; march out and do battle on behalf of our
people, and may aid from heaven go with you." 4 So John chose from
the country twenty thousand fighting men and horsemen, and they
marched against Cendebeus and spent the night at Modein. 5 Rising
early, they advanced into the plain, where a great host of foot and
horse came marching against them, with a stream between the two
armies. 6 John and his men took up position facing the enemy. Seeing
that his men were afraid to cross the stream, he crossed over first;
and when the men saw him, they crossed after him. 7 He divided
his army, placing the horsemen in the midst of the foot soldiers, for
the enemy's cavalry was very numerous. 8 They blew the trumpets,
and Cendebeus and his army fled. Many of them fell wounded, and
the rest ran to the fortress. 9 It was then that John's brother Judas
was wounded; but John pursued the enemy until he came to Kedron,
which Cendebeus had built. 10 They fled to the towers in the fields of
Azotus, and John burned it[a] with fire. About a thousand of them fell,
and he returned to Judea in safety.
11 Now Ptolemy son of Abubus had been made governor of the plain of
Jericho, and he possessed a great deal of silver and gold, 12 for he was
the high priest's son-in-law. 13 His heart grew proud, and he resolved
to make himself master of the country; so he plotted treachery against
Simon and his sons, to do away with them. 14 Simon was traveling
through the towns of the country, seeing to their needs. In the
year 177 (134 BC), in the eleventh month (in January–February), the
month of Shebat,[b] he went down to Jericho with his sons Mattathias
and Judas. 15 The son of Abubus received them with guile in the small
fort he had built, named Dok.[c] There he held a great drinking feast
for them, having hidden men in the place. 16 When Simon and his sons
were drunk, Ptolemy and his men sprang up, grabbed their weapons,
and burst in on Simon in the banquet hall; they murdered him, along
with his two sons and some of his servants. 17 So he committed a great
act of treachery and repaid good with evil.
18 Then Ptolemy put these things in writing and dispatched it to the
king, urging him to send forces to his support and to hand over to

him their country and towns. 19 He sent other men to Gazara to do
away with John, and he sent letters to the officers of the thousands,
inviting them to come to him so that he might give them silver, gold,
and gifts. 20 Still others he sent to take possession of Jerusalem and the
temple hill. 21 But a messenger outran them and told John at Gazara
that his father and brothers were dead, and said, "He has sent men
to kill you too." 22 When John heard this, he was deeply shaken. He
seized the men who had been sent to kill him and executed them,
because he had learned that they were trying to kill him.
23 The rest of John's story, his wars and the brave deeds he performed,
the walls he built, and his other accomplishments, 24 are recorded in
the annals of his high priesthood, from the time he succeeded his
father as high priest.[d]

Notes

- a (16:10) "It" probably refers to Azotus; some take it to mean the town of Kedron. Swete's Greek reads "about a thousand" of the enemy fell; some ancient witnesses read "two thousand."
- b (16:14) Greek: in the 177th year, in the eleventh month, which is the month of Shebat (Seleucid era; see note on 1:10). Shebat (Shevat) is January–February.
- c (16:15) Dok, a small fortress on a hill above Jericho.
- d (16:24) John Hyrcanus ruled 134–104 BC. No such annals are known to survive.

2 Maccabees

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 To their kindred, the Jews throughout Egypt, greetings from their
kindred, the Jews in Jerusalem and in the land of Judea: true peace.
2 May God do you good, and may he remember his covenant with
Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, his faithful servants. 3 May he give all of
you a heart to worship him and to carry out his will with a great
heart and a willing spirit. 4 May he open your hearts to his law and
commandments, and may he give you peace. 5 May he listen to your
prayers and be reconciled with you, and never abandon you in a time
of trouble. 6 Here and now we are praying for you.
7 In the reign of Demetrius, in the year 143 BC,[a] we Jews wrote to you:
"During the suffering and crisis that fell on us in those years, after
Jason and his supporters betrayed the holy land and the kingdom,[b]
8 they set fire to the gateway and shed innocent blood. Then we
pleaded with the Lord and were heard; we offered sacrifice and fine
flour, we lit the lamps, and we set out the loaves." 9 And now see that
you keep the days of Booths in the month of Chislev (in November–
December).[c] 10 Written in the year 124 BC.[d] From those in Jerusalem
and Judea, the senate, and Judas, to Aristobulus, who is of the stock
of the anointed priests and tutor to King Ptolemy, and to the Jews
of Egypt: greeting, and health.[e] 11 Having been rescued by God from
grave dangers, we give him great thanks, as men who stood in battle
array against a king. 12 For it was he who hurled out those who drew
up for battle against the holy city. 13 When the leader reached Persia
with an army that seemed irresistible, they were cut to pieces in the
temple of Nanea through a trick employed by Nanea's priests.[f] 14 On
the pretext of marrying the goddess, Antiochus came to the place
with his Friends, meaning to take its great riches as a dowry. 15 The
priests of Nanea had laid out the treasures, and Antiochus went inside

the walls of the sacred area with a small escort; as soon as he was in, they locked the temple. 16 Opening a secret door in the paneled ceiling, they hurled stones and struck down the leader as if with thunderbolts; then they cut the bodies in pieces and threw the heads to those outside. 17 Our God be praised in all things, he who gave up the impious to judgment!

18 We are about to keep the cleansing of the sanctuary on the twenty-fifth of Chislev (in November–December), and so we judged it needful to make this known to you, that you also may observe a feast of Booths and of the fire which appeared when Nehemiah, the builder of the sanctuary and altar, brought up sacrifices.[g] 19 For when our ancestors were being led away to Persia, devout priests of that time secretly took some of the fire from the altar and hid it in the hollow of a dry cistern, where they made it secure, so that the place was unknown to anyone. 20 After many years had passed, when it pleased God, Nehemiah, sent by the king of Persia, dispatched the descendants of the priests who had hidden the fire to recover it. 21 They told us they had found no fire, only a thick liquid. He ordered them to scoop some up and bring it. After the materials for the sacrifices had been laid on the altar, Nehemiah commanded the priests to splash the liquid over the wood and everything on it. 22 When this was done and some time had passed, and the sun, which had been behind clouds, shone out, a great blaze flared up, so that everyone marveled. 23 And as the offering burned, the priests made prayer, both priests and all the rest, Jonathan beginning and the others answering, as Nehemiah did. 24 The prayer went like this: "O Lord, Lord God, Creator of all things, awe-inspiring and strong, just and merciful, you alone are King and kind, 25 you alone are bountiful, you alone are just, almighty, and eternal. You rescue Israel from every evil; you made our ancestors your chosen ones and consecrated them. 26 Receive the offering for the whole of Israel your people; keep safe your inheritance and sanctify it. 27 Bring our dispersion together again; free those in bondage among the Gentiles; regard the scorned and abhorred; and so let the Gentiles learn that you are our God. 28 Punish those who oppress us and insolently abuse

us in their arrogance. 29 Plant your people in your holy place, as Moses
said." 30 Then the priests sang the hymns.
31 Once the sacrifice was burned up, Nehemiah gave orders to pour
what remained of the liquid upon some large stones. 32 When this was
done, a flame blazed up, but it was consumed by the light that shone
back from the altar.[h] 33 Once the affair came to light, the Persian king
was told that where the priests carried into exile had concealed the
fire, liquid had been found, and that Nehemiah's company had used
it to purify the offerings. 34 The king fenced off the place and made
it sacred, after investigating the matter. 35 And to those on whom the
king bestowed favor, he gave a share of the many gifts he received.[i]
36 Nehemiah's company gave this the name nephthar, interpreted as
"cleansing"; but among most it goes by the name naphtha.[j]

Notes

- a (1:7) Greek: in the 169th year (Seleucid era). The Seleucid era is the reckoning used in the books of Maccabees, counted from the founding of the Seleucid kingdom in autumn 312 BC or spring 311 BC; converted years may be off by one. Demetrius is Demetrius II.
- b (1:7) Jason the high priest; see 4:7–26 and 5:5–10.
- c (1:9) Literally "the days of Booths of the month of Chislev," that is, the festival of the temple's rededication (Hanukkah), kept for eight days in the manner of Booths; see 10:6. Chislev is the ninth month, November–December.
- d (1:10) Greek: in the 188th year (Seleucid era; see note on 1:7). Many interpreters attach this date to the first letter; others take it as the opening of the second letter.
- e (1:10) Aristobulus was a Jewish philosopher of Alexandria; the king is probably Ptolemy VI Philometor. The second letter (1:10–2:18) claims to come from Judas Maccabeus and so would date from about 164 BC.
- f (1:13) Nanea (Nanaia) was a goddess worshiped in Persia and Mesopotamia. This account of the death of Antiochus differs from 1 Macc 6:1–16 and 2 Macc 9; it may reflect the death of Antiochus III in 187 BC, who died plundering a temple in Elymais.
- g (1:18) Chislev is the ninth month, November–December. The traditional reconstruction of the temple was by Zerubbabel and Joshua (Ezra 3–6); this tradition credits Nehemiah.
- h (1:32) The sense of this verse is uncertain.
- i (1:35) Or "the king took many gifts and gave a share to them"; the Greek is obscure.
- j (1:36) Nephthar is of uncertain origin and meaning; the explanation "purification" is the author's. Naphtha is a flammable petroleum liquid.

Chapter 2

1 The records show that the prophet Jeremiah instructed those being
taken into exile to take some of the fire with them, as already
described, 2 and that the prophet, having handed them the law,
charged the deportees not to forget the Lord's ordinances, nor to be
led astray in their thoughts on seeing images of gold and silver and
their finery. 3 With other such words he exhorted them never to let the
law depart from their hearts. 4 The writing also told how the prophet,
warned by an oracle, ordered the tent and the ark to go along with
him, and how he went out to the mountain that Moses had climbed
to view God's inheritance.[a] 5 Arriving there, Jeremiah found a cave-
like dwelling, and into it he carried the tent, the ark, and the altar of
incense; then he blocked up the entrance. 6 Some of his companions
came up afterward meaning to mark the way, but they could not find
it. 7 When Jeremiah learned of this, he rebuked them: "Unknown that
place will be, until God brings his people together in one assembly
and mercy comes. 8 Then the Lord will reveal where they are, and the
Lord's glory and the cloud will appear, just as they were displayed in
the days of Moses, and when Solomon prayed that the place would
be wonderfully consecrated." 9 It was also made clear how Solomon,
being endowed with wisdom, offered a sacrifice for the dedication
and completion of the sanctuary. 10 Just as Moses prayed to the Lord
and fire came down from heaven and devoured the sacrifices, so too
Solomon prayed, and the fire descended and consumed the whole
burnt offerings. 11 And Moses said, "Because the sin offering had not
been eaten, it was consumed."[b] 12 Likewise Solomon too kept the eight
days.[c]

13 The same things are also recorded in the archives and in Nehemiah's
memoirs, which add that he founded a library and gathered the books
about the kings and the prophets, the writings of David, and the
kings' letters about gifts dedicated to God.[d] 14 In the same way Judas
also gathered up all the books that had been scattered because of the
war that befell us, and we have them in our possession. 15 So if you
need any of them, send people to fetch them for you.

16 Since, then, we are about to celebrate the purification, we write to
you. You will do well, therefore, to keep these days. 17 It is God who
has saved all his people and has given back to all the inheritance, the
kingship, the priesthood, and the consecration, 18 as he pledged in the
law. Our hope rests on God, that he will be quick to pity us and to
gather us from everywhere under heaven into the holy place; for out
of great evils he delivered us, and he cleansed the place.
19 The story of Judas Maccabeus and his brothers,[e] the purification of
the great temple, and the dedication of the altar, 20 and further the
wars against Antiochus Epiphanes and his son Eupator,[f] 21 and the
manifestations from heaven granted to those who strove valiantly,
with honor, on behalf of Judaism,[g] so that, few as they were, they
overran the whole land and chased off the barbarian multitudes, 22
and won back the temple renowned throughout the inhabited world,
and set the city free, and reestablished the laws then on the verge
of being overthrown, the Lord in all his gentleness being merciful
toward them, 23 all this, made known by Jason the Cyrenian in five
books, we will try to shorten into one composition. 24 For we saw
the flood of figures, and the difficulty that the sheer mass of material
poses for anyone wishing to plunge into the narratives of the history,
25 and we have aimed to bring delight to those who wish to read, ease
to those inclined to commit things to memory, and benefit to all who
come upon the work. 26 For us who have taken on the toil of abridging,
the task is no easy one; it is a matter of sweat and sleepless nights, 27
just as it is no light thing for one preparing a banquet who seeks the
enjoyment of others. Even so, for the sake of the gratitude of many,
we shall gladly endure the toil, 28 leaving to the original author the
precise treatment of every detail, while we exert ourselves to follow
the outlines of an abridgment. 29 For as the master builder of a new
house must concern himself with the entire structure, while the one
who undertakes to paint and decorate it must look into what is
suitable for adornment, so I judge it to be in our case. 30 To enter into
the subject, to range over it in discussion, and to busy oneself with
particulars is the task of the first compiler of the history; 31 but the
one who recasts it must be allowed to aim at brevity of expression

and to forgo exhaustive treatment. 32 So at this point let us begin the narrative, adding only this much to what has been said; it would be foolish to go on at length in the preface and then shorten the history itself.

Notes

- a (2:4) Mount Nebo; see Deut 32:49; 34:1–4.
- b (2:11) See Lev 10:16–20.
- c (2:12) See 1 Kings 8:65–66; 2 Chr 7:8–10.
- d (2:13) "Votive offerings": gifts dedicated to the temple.
- e (2:19) Maccabeus, the surname of Judas, perhaps means "hammer" (Aramaic maqqaba), but the meaning is uncertain.
- f (2:20) Antiochus IV Epiphanes ("God manifest") and his son Antiochus V Eupator ("of a noble father").
- g (2:21) This is the earliest known use of the Greek word "Judaism," the name for the Jewish way of life; compare 8:1; 14:38.

Chapter 3

1 The holy city lived in complete peace and the laws were observed with great faithfulness, thanks to the devotion of Onias the high priest and his loathing of evil,[a] 2 and so the kings themselves honored the place and enhanced the temple with magnificent gifts, 3 so that even Seleucus, king of Asia, met from his own revenues all the costs connected with the service of the sacrifices.[b]

4 But a certain Simon, of the tribe of Benjamin,[c] who had been appointed captain of the temple, fell into a dispute with the high priest about the regulation of the city market. 5 Unable to prevail over Onias, he went to Apollonius son of Thraseas, who at that time was governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia,[d] 6 and informed him that the treasury in Jerusalem was overflowing with immense amounts of money, too much to count, and that it had nothing to do with the sacrificial accounts but could come under the king's control. 7 When Apollonius met the king, he told him of the money that had been disclosed to him. The king chose Heliodorus, his chief minister, and sent him with orders to carry off the reported wealth.[e] 8 Heliodorus at once took the road, in appearance to visit the towns of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, but in reality to accomplish what the king intended. 9 On arriving at Jerusalem and being kindly welcomed by the high

priest of the city, he laid before him the information that had been given and made plain why he had come, and he asked whether these things were really so. 10 The high priest explained that there were deposits belonging to widows and orphans, 11 and that some belonged to Hyrcanus son of Tobias, a man holding a very eminent place. So far was it from what Simon, that ungodly man, alleged. The whole came to fifteen tons of silver and seven and a half tons of gold.[f] 12 It was completely unthinkable to wrong people who had trusted in the holiness of the place and in the sacredness and inviolability of a temple honored all over the world. 13 But Heliodorus insisted, because of the king's orders, that the money had to be seized for the royal treasury in any case.

14 Fixing a day, he went in to manage the examination of these funds, and anguish of no small degree gripped the entire city. 15 The priests flung themselves down before the altar in their priestly robes and cried out to Heaven, to the one who had laid down the law concerning deposits, asking him to preserve these intact for those who had placed them there. 16 Whoever looked on the high priest's countenance was pierced in mind, for his appearance and his altered complexion revealed the agony within his soul. 17 Fear and a shuddering of the body had spread over him, and by these the grief settled in his heart was made evident to the onlookers. 18 Crowds of people also ran out of their houses to join in a public plea, because the holy place was about to be disgraced. 19 The women, with sackcloth bound beneath their breasts, filled the roadways in great numbers; and of the virgins kept in seclusion, some ran to the gateways, some to the walls, and some leaned out to look through the windows. 20 And all of them, stretching out their hands toward heaven, made their entreaty. 21 It was pitiable to see the multitude prostrate in a mixed throng, and the anxious expectation of the high priest in his great anguish.

22 While they were calling upon the almighty Lord to keep the things entrusted safe and secure for those who had entrusted them, 23 Heliodorus went on with what had been decided. 24 But when he was already present at the treasury with his guards, the Ruler over spirits and every power made a great appearing, so that all who had dared

to come along were struck with dismay at God's might and gave way to weakness and fear. [25] For a horse appeared to them, carrying a terrifying rider and decked with the most beautiful harness; charging violently, it lashed at Heliodorus with its forefeet, and the one mounted on it seemed to wear a full suit of golden armor. [26] Two other young men also appeared to him, remarkably strong, splendid in beauty, and gorgeously dressed; they stood on either side of him and flogged him without pause, inflicting many blows on him. [27] When he had suddenly fallen to the ground and was enveloped in deep darkness, they picked him up, put him on a stretcher, [28] and carried away the man who had just entered that treasury with a great retinue and all his bodyguard, now helpless; and they plainly recognized the sovereign power of God. [29] So he, by God's working, lay cast down, voiceless and bereft of every hope of rescue, [30] while they blessed the Lord who had wondrously glorified his own place; and the sanctuary, so lately brimming with dread and confusion, was now full of joy and rejoicing, since the almighty Lord had shown himself.

[31] Soon certain of Heliodorus's intimates asked Onias to call on the Most High and grant life to the man who lay at his very last gasp. [32] The high priest, fearing that the king might suspect that some foul play had been done to Heliodorus by the Jews, offered a sacrifice for the man's recovery. [33] As the high priest was offering the sacrifice of atonement, those same youths, clad in the same garments, once more appeared to Heliodorus. Standing there, they said, "Owe Onias the high priest much thanks; on his account the Lord has granted you life. [34] As for you, scourged from heaven, proclaim to everyone God's mighty strength." When they had said this, they were seen no more. [35] Heliodorus then offered a sacrifice to the Lord and made extravagant vows to the one who had spared his life; he said goodbye to Onias and marched his troops back to the king. [36] He bore testimony to everyone of the deeds of the supreme God that he had seen with his own eyes. [37] The king asked Heliodorus who might be a fit man to dispatch once again to Jerusalem, and he answered: [38] "Should you have some foe or someone scheming against the state, dispatch him there, and you will receive him back well scourged, if indeed he comes through alive; for

truly a power of God surrounds that place. 39 The one whose abode is in heaven is himself its overseer and helper, and those who arrive there to do it harm he smites and destroys." 40 This was the outcome of the affair of Heliodorus and the protection of the treasury.

Notes

- a (3:1) Onias III, high priest about 196–175 BC.
- b (3:3) Seleucus IV Philopator, king 187–175 BC.
- c (3:4) Some ancient witnesses read "of Bilgah," a priestly family (Neh 12:5, 18).
- d (3:5) Coelesyria ("Hollow Syria") was the region between the Lebanon ranges, extending in official usage to Palestine.
- e (3:7) Literally "the one in charge of affairs."
- f (3:11) Greek: four hundred talents of silver and two hundred talents of gold. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg).

Chapter 4

1 But the aforesaid Simon, who had turned informer against the funds and against his own homeland, went about slandering Onias, as if it were Onias who had stirred Heliodorus up and had been the author of these evils. 2 He dared to call the city's benefactor, the protector of his fellow countrymen and zealous upholder of the laws, a conspirator against the state. 3 When the enmity advanced so far that even murders were carried out by one of Simon's trusted agents, 4 Onias saw how dangerous the rivalry was, and that Apollonius son of Menestheus, governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, was fanning Simon's malice.[a] 5 So he betook himself to the king, not as an accuser of his fellow citizens but with an eye to the welfare, both public and private, of all the people. 6 For he saw that without the king's attention it was impossible for public affairs to find peace, and that Simon would not cease from his folly.

7 When Seleucus died and Antiochus, known as Epiphanes, took the throne, Jason, the brother of Onias, got the high priesthood through bribery,[b] 8 promising the king in a petition about thirteen and a half tons of silver, and from some other revenue about three tons more.[c] 9 Besides this he engaged to pay in writing about five and a half tons further, if leave were given him by the king's authority to found a gymnasium and a training corps of youths, and to register the people

of Jerusalem as citizens of Antioch.[d] 10 The king agreed; and as soon as
Jason held the office, he immediately moved his countrymen over to
the Greek way of life. 11 He set aside the royal privileges granted to the
Jews, obtained through John the father of Eupolemus, who had gone
on the embassy to the Romans for friendship and alliance;[e] and abol-
ishing the lawful ways of life, he brought in new customs contrary
to the law. 12 With relish he founded a gymnasium right below the
citadel, and he made the noblest of the young men submit to wearing
the broad-brimmed hat.[f] 13 Thus Hellenism reached its height and the
adoption of alien customs advanced, through the boundless profanity
of Jason, an impious man and in no way a high priest, 14 that the
priests were no longer eager for the services of the altar. Despising
the sanctuary and neglecting the sacrifices, they hastened, once the
gong summoned for the discus, to take part in the unlawful exercises
provided in the wrestling school.[g] 15 Counting their ancestral honors
as nothing, they prized Greek distinctions above all. 16 For this reason
a grievous calamity overtook them, and the very people whose ways
they envied and wished to resemble in every respect became their
enemies and punishers. 17 For to act impiously against the divine laws
is no light matter, as the period that follows will show.

18 When the games held every fifth year were being celebrated at
Tyre, and the king was present,[h] 19 the polluted Jason sent official
delegates, purporting to be Antiochenes from Jerusalem, conveying
nearly three pounds of silver for the sacrifice to Heracles.[i] But the
bearers themselves thought it unfitting to spend it on a sacrifice, 20
and so, on account of those bringing it, it went to the construction
of warships.[j]

21 Apollonius son of Menestheus was dispatched to Egypt for the
enthronement of King Philometor,[k] and Antiochus, discovering that
Philometor had turned unfriendly toward his interests, looked to
his own safety. So he went to Joppa and from there came down to
Jerusalem. 22 He was received in grand style by Jason and the city and
was ushered in with torchlight and shouting. After that he marched
his army into Phoenicia.

23 After three years, Jason sent Menelaus, brother of the Simon
mentioned above, to deliver the money to the king and to finish the
records on urgent business.[l] 24 But Menelaus, once presented to the
king, flattered him with the bearing of a man of power and so drew
the high priesthood to himself, outbidding Jason by about eleven tons
of silver.[m] 25 After receiving the king's commission he returned, bring-
ing nothing worthy of the high priesthood but having the passions
of a cruel tyrant and the rage of a savage beast. 26 So Jason, who had
undermined his own brother, was undermined in turn by another and
was driven as a fugitive into the land of Ammon. 27 Menelaus kept
firm hold of the office, but of the money promised to the king he paid
nothing in due order. 28 Sostratus, the citadel's commandant, pressed
for payment, for the collecting of the dues belonged to him; and on
this account both men were called before the king. 29 Menelaus left his
own brother Lysimachus as his deputy in the high priesthood, and
Sostratus left Crates, the commander of the Cypriots, in his place.[n]
30 Matters standing thus, the citizens of Tarsus and Mallus rose in
revolt, since their towns had been handed over as a gift to Antiochis, a
concubine of the king. 31 So the king went off in haste to settle matters,
leaving as his deputy Andronicus, a man of high rank. 32 Menelaus,
supposing a favorable moment had come, purloined certain golden
vessels belonging to the sanctuary and made a present of them to
Andronicus; others he had already sold off in Tyre and the neighbor-
ing towns. 33 When Onias had clear knowledge of this, he exposed him
publicly, having withdrawn to a place of sanctuary at Daphne near
Antioch.[o] 34 Therefore Menelaus, taking Andronicus aside, urged him
to kill Onias. Andronicus went to Onias, and resorting to treachery,
gave him his right hand with oaths. Though still suspected, he per-
suaded Onias to come out from the sanctuary, and at once he shut
him away and killed him, with no regard for justice.[p] 35 For this reason
not only Jews but many people of other nations too were indignant
and displeased at the unjust murder of the man. 36 On the king's return
from the districts of Cilicia, the city's Jews appealed to him, joined
by Greeks who shared their loathing of wrongdoing, concerning the
senseless slaying of Onias. 37 Antiochus was grieved at heart and

moved to pity, and he wept because of the moderation and great good conduct of the deceased. [38] Blazing with anger, he immediately took off Andronicus's purple robe and ripped his clothes off, then led him through the whole city to the very spot where he had committed the crime against Onias; there he killed the murderer, as the Lord paid him back with the punishment he deserved.

[39] When many sacrileges had been committed in the city by Lysimachus with the connivance of Menelaus, and the report had spread abroad, the populace gathered against Lysimachus, for many of the gold vessels had already been carried off. [40] As the crowds were rising and becoming filled with rage, Lysimachus armed about three thousand men and began unjust violence, with a certain Auranus leading, a man advanced in years and no less in folly. [41] When the people saw the attack of Lysimachus, some seized stones, some thick pieces of wood, and others grabbed handfuls of the ashes lying near, and they hurled them in wild confusion at Lysimachus and his men. [42] As a result they wounded many of them, struck down some, and put all of them to flight; and the temple robber himself they killed beside the treasury.

[43] A charge was brought against Menelaus over these matters. [44] When the king came to Tyre, the three men sent by the council of elders presented the case before him. [45] But Menelaus, already losing, offered Ptolemy son of Dorymenes a substantial sum if he would bring the king round. [46] So Ptolemy, taking the king aside into a colonnade as if for fresh air, induced him to change his mind. [47] Menelaus, the cause of all the evil, he acquitted of the charges, while the unfortunate men, who would have been freed as innocent even if they had pleaded before Scythians, he sentenced to death.ᑫ [48] So those who had pleaded on behalf of the city, the country districts, and the sacred vessels swiftly underwent that undeserved punishment. [49] For this cause Tyrians too, out of abhorrence of the wickedness, bore the cost of their funeral with great generosity. [50] Yet Menelaus kept his office through the covetousness of the powerful, ever thriving in wickedness, set up as the great traitor to his fellow citizens.

Notes

- a (4:4) In 3:5 the governor is called Apollonius son of Thraseas; the relation of the two names is uncertain.
- b (4:7) Antiochus IV Epiphanes became king in 175 BC.
- c (4:8) Greek: three hundred sixty talents of silver, and eighty talents. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg).
- d (4:9) Greek: one hundred fifty talents (see note on 4:8). Or "to register the Antiochenes in Jerusalem"; the Greek may refer to a citizen body of Antioch formed within Jerusalem.
- e (4:11) See 1 Macc 8:17.
- f (4:12) The petasos, a broad-brimmed hat associated with Hermes, patron of athletics, was worn by youths in the gymnasium.
- g (4:14) Or "after the signal for the discus"; the Greek is uncertain.
- h (4:18) Games in honor of Heracles (Melqart) held at Tyre every four years (counted inclusively as the fifth).
- i (4:19) Greek: three hundred drachmas. The drachma, a silver coin, weighed about 0.15 ounce (4.3 g). Heracles was identified with Melqart, god of Tyre. Some ancient witnesses read "three thousand three hundred."
- j (4:20) Literally "on account of those present"; the sense is uncertain.
- k (4:21) Greek protoklisia, apparently the enthronement of Ptolemy VI Philometor, about 172 BC.
- l (4:23) About 172 BC.
- m (4:24) Greek: three hundred talents (see note on 4:8).
- n (4:29) Mercenaries from Cyprus.
- o (4:33) Daphne, a suburb of Antioch, had a famous sanctuary of Apollo and Artemis with right of asylum.
- p (4:34) Onias III was killed about 170 BC.
- q (4:47) The Scythians, from north of the Black Sea, were proverbial for barbarity.

Chapter 5

1 About this time Antiochus made his second expedition into Egypt.[a]
2 And it came about that over the whole city, for nearly forty days, there appeared horsemen racing through the air, clad in garments woven with gold, armed with lances in companies, 3 swords drawn, troops of cavalry drawn up in order, charges and countercharges on either side, shields brandished, a forest of spears, missiles flying, the flash of golden ornaments, and armor of every kind. 4 So everyone prayed that the apparition might prove a good omen.
5 When a false rumor arose that Antiochus had departed this life, Jason took no fewer than a thousand men and made a sudden assault on the city. The defenders on the wall were driven back, and when at

last the city was being taken, Menelaus fled for refuge into the citadel.
6 But Jason went on slaughtering his own fellow citizens without
mercy, not perceiving that success against one's own kindred is the
greatest failure, but imagining that he was setting up trophies over
enemies and not over his own nation. 7 He did not win the office; in
the end he gained only shame from his plot and passed again as a
fugitive into the land of Ammon. 8 In the end he came to a miserable
death. Imprisoned by Aretas, the ruler of the Arabs,[b] he ran from city
to city, hunted by everyone, hated as a lawbreaker, and despised as
the butcher of his own country and people, and he was cast up on the
shore in Egypt. 9 He who had driven many from their own land into
exile died in exile, having sailed off to the Lacedaemonians in hope
of finding shelter there on account of kinship.[c] 10 He who had thrown
out multitudes to lie unburied went unmourned himself, and had no
funeral of any kind, nor any place in an ancestral tomb.
11 When news of what had happened reached the king, he concluded
that Judea was in revolt. So, setting out from Egypt raging like a wild
beast, he took the city by storm. 12 He commanded his soldiers to cut
down without mercy those they met, and to slay those who went up
onto the housetops. 13 Young and old were killed; boys, women and
children were destroyed; unmarried girls and infants were slaugh-
tered. 14 Within the space of three days eighty thousand were lost,
forty thousand in hand-to-hand fighting, and as many again were
sold as slaves as were slain.
15 Not satisfied with this, he made bold to go into the sanctuary holiest
on all the earth, with Menelaus as his guide, that betrayer of the
laws and of his native land. 16 With polluted hands he seized the holy
vessels, and with profane hands he swept away the offerings that
other kings had set up to enhance the glory and honor of the place.
17 Antiochus grew haughty in mind, failing to see that the Master's
anger had been roused briefly over the sins of the city's inhabitants,
and that this accounted for his neglect of the place. 18 But had they not
happened to be entangled in many sins, this man too, like Heliodorus
whom King Seleucus sent to inspect the treasury, would have been
flogged as soon as he came forward and turned back from his rash

act. [19] Yet it was not for the place's sake that the Lord chose the people;
rather, he chose the place for the people's sake. [20] So the place itself,
having partaken in the calamities that came upon the people, later
had its part in their blessings; abandoned when the Almighty was
angry, it was set up again with all splendor once the great Master was
reconciled.
[21] So Antiochus took away about sixty-eight tons from the sanctuary[d]
and hastened off to Antioch, supposing in his pride that he could sail
upon dry land and march across the open sea, such was the loftiness
of his heart. [22] He left governors to afflict the people: at Jerusalem,
Philip, by race a Phrygian and in character more barbarous than
the man who appointed him; [23] and Andronicus at Gerizim; and in
addition Menelaus, who ruled over his fellow citizens more harshly
than the others did, and who held a hateful attitude toward the
Jewish citizens.[e] [24] He sent Apollonius, the Mysian commander,[f] at the
head of an army of twenty-two thousand, ordering him to kill every
adult man and to sell the women and the young. [25] When Apollonius
reached Jerusalem, he pretended to come in peace and waited until
the holy sabbath day; then, finding the Jews resting, he ordered his
troops to march in formation under arms. [26] All who came out to
watch he put to the sword, and rushing into the city with his armed
men he killed great numbers.
[27] But Judas Maccabeus, with about nine others, withdrew into the
wilderness and lived like wild animals in the mountains with his
companions; they continued to eat what grew wild, so as not to share
in the defilement.[g]

Notes

- a (5:1) About 168 BC. Some historians count this as the king's second campaign, others as his third.
- b (5:8) Aretas I, king of the Nabateans. Greek tyrannos here means "ruler," not necessarily "tyrant."
- c (5:9) The Spartans claimed kinship with the Jews; see 1 Macc 12:6–23.
- d (5:21) A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg).
- e (5:23) Or "having a hostile disposition toward the citizens, being Jews"; the Greek is uncertain.

- f (5:24) Greek mysarchēs, perhaps "commander of the Mysians" (mercenaries from Asia Minor), or a pun meaning "chief of the abominable"; compare 1 Macc 1:29.
- g (5:27) Literally "being himself about the tenth." See 1 Macc 2:28.

Chapter 6

1 Not long afterward the king sent out an old Athenian[a] to force the Jews to abandon their ancestral laws and to cease living by the laws of God, 2 and also to defile the sanctuary in Jerusalem and name it after Olympian Zeus, and the one at Gerizim after Zeus the Protector of Strangers, in keeping with the character of those who dwelt in that place.[b] 3 Harsh and hard for everyone to bear was the onset of this evil. 4 For the sanctuary was filled with debauchery and reveling by Gentiles who idled with prostitutes and had intercourse with women within the sacred courts, and who moreover carried in things that were forbidden. 5 The altar was heaped with abominable offerings, prohibited by the laws. 6 One could neither keep the sabbath nor observe the ancestral feasts, nor so much as confess oneself to be a Jew. 7 On the king's birthday each month they were led, under bitter compulsion, to partake of the sacrificial entrails;[c] and when the festival of Dionysus came round, they were compelled to walk in the procession for Dionysus wearing wreaths of ivy. 8 By a motion of Ptolemy,[d] an edict was published to the Greek towns round about, directing them to treat the Jews in the same fashion and make them eat of the sacrifices, 9 and should put to death those who did not choose to go over to Greek ways. So one could see the misery that had come. 10 For instance, two women were brought in for having circumcised their children. They hung the babies at their mothers' breasts, paraded the women publicly about the city, and flung them headlong from the wall. 11 Others, who had gathered nearby in caves in order to keep the seventh day in secret, were betrayed to Philip and were all burned together, because their reverence for that most holy day kept them from defending themselves.

12 Now I urge those who come upon this book not to lose heart because of these calamities, but to consider that these punishments were meant not for the destruction of our race but for its discipline. 13 Indeed, not to let the ungodly alone for long, but to bring retribution

on them swiftly, is a sign of great kindness. 14 With other nations,
the Lord patiently waits to punish them until their sins have reached
their full measure; but he chose not to treat us in that way, 15 lest he
should take vengeance on us afterward, when our sins have come to
their full height. 16 Therefore he never withdraws his mercy from us.
Though he disciplines with calamity, he does not abandon his own
people. 17 But let this much be said by way of reminder; after these
few words we must come back to the narrative.
18 Eleazar, one of the foremost scribes, a man already advanced in age
and of most noble bearing, was being forced to open his mouth to
eat swine's flesh. 19 But he, preferring death with honor to life with
defilement, spat it out[e] and went of his own accord to the rack, 20 as
men ought to come forward who have the courage to refuse what it
is not lawful to taste, even out of love of life. 21 The overseers of that
lawless feast of sacrifice, since they had known the man from long
ago, drew him aside in private and pressed him to have meat brought
that he himself had prepared and that he was allowed to eat, and to
make a show of eating the portions of sacrificial flesh commanded by
the king, 22 so that by doing this he might be released from death and,
for the sake of his old friendship with them, be treated kindly. 23 But he
formed a lofty judgment, one that befitted his age, the eminence of his
advanced years, the gray hair he had won to his honor, his blameless
manner of life from boyhood, and still more the holy legislation
established by God; and he made answer accordingly, bidding them
dispatch him to Hades without delay.[f] 24 "It does not befit our time of
life to pretend," he said, "lest many of the young suppose that Eleazar
at ninety years has gone over to an alien religion, 25 and through my
pretense, for the sake of a brief moment of life, they be led astray
because of me, while I bring defilement and disgrace upon my old age.
26 Even if I escape human punishment for now, I will not escape the
hands of the Almighty, whether I live or die. 27 So by giving up my life
bravely now, I will prove myself worthy of my old age, 28 bequeathing
to the young a noble pattern, so that they may meet a good death
eagerly and gallantly on behalf of the sacred and holy laws." When he
had said so much, he went straightway to the rack. 29 Those who led

him, who a little before had been kindly disposed toward him, now turned hostile, because the words he had just spoken were in their opinion sheer madness. 30 As he was about to die from the blows, he groaned and said, "The Lord, whose knowledge is holy, can see that I could have escaped death, yet I am suffering terrible pain in my body from this beating; but in my soul I gladly endure it, because I fear him." 31 Such was the manner of his death; and to the young, and to most of his people as well, he left behind his dying as a pattern of high courage and a remembrance of virtue.

Notes

- a (6:1) Or "Geron the Athenian"; Greek gerōn means "old man" and may also be a proper name. Some ancient witnesses read "an Antiochian."
- b (6:2) Zeus Xenios, protector of strangers. The phrase "in keeping with the character of those who dwelt in that place" may refer to the Samaritans' hospitality or, ironically, to their being of foreign origin; the Greek is uncertain.
- c (6:7) Or "to the monthly sacrifice" on the king's birthday.
- d (6:8) Probably Ptolemy son of Dorymenes (4:45); compare 8:8.
- e (6:19) Or "led himself to it"; the Greek of vv. 19–20 is compressed.
- f (6:23) Hades, the abode of the dead.

Chapter 7

1 It happened also that seven brothers were arrested along with their mother, and the king tried to compel them, by torturing them with whips and thongs, to touch the forbidden pig's flesh. 2 One of them, acting as spokesman, said, "What do you intend to ask us and learn from us? We stand ready to die sooner than transgress the laws of our fathers." 3 In a fury the king commanded pans and caldrons to be heated red-hot. 4 As soon as they were heated, he ordered the tongue of their spokesman to be cut out, the skin of his head to be torn away in the Scythian manner, and his hands and feet to be lopped off, while his remaining brothers and his mother looked on. 5 After he was left totally helpless, the king ordered him brought to the fire while still breathing and fried in a pan. As the smoke from the pan drifted far and wide, the brothers and their mother kept encouraging each other to die bravely, saying: 6 "The Lord God is watching over us and truly feels compassion for us, as Moses made clear in the song

that testifies against the people to their faces, when he said, 'He will have compassion on his servants.'"[a]
7 When the first had died in this way, they brought forward the second to be made sport of. They tore off the skin of his head along with the hair and asked him, "Will you eat, before your body is punished limb by limb?" 8 He answered in the language of his ancestors[b] and told them, "No." So he too underwent the tortures in turn, as the first had done. 9 And at his final gasp he said, "Fiend that you are, you set us free from life here and now; but since we die on behalf of his laws, the King of the world will raise us to an eternal return to life."
10 After him the third was made a mockery. When they demanded his tongue, he quickly thrust it out, and he courageously stretched forth his hands, 11 and nobly said, "From Heaven I received these, and for the sake of his laws I count them as nothing, and from him I hope to receive them back again." 12 so that the king and his company were amazed at the youth's courage, since he treated the pains as of no account.
13 When this one too had died, they mistreated and tortured the fourth in the same way. 14 Close to death, he spoke these words: "Better it is for those who pass away at human hands to look for the hopes that come from God, that they will be raised by him once more. For you, though, there will be no rising again to life."
15 Next they led forward the fifth and abused him. 16 Looking at the king, he said, "You hold authority among mortals, though you yourself are perishable, and you do what you please. But do not imagine that God has forsaken our race. 17 Only wait, and you will behold his mighty power, how he will torment you and your descendants."
18 After him they brought the sixth. On the point of dying, he said, "Do not be led astray to no purpose. We suffer these things on our own account, for we sinned against our own God; that is why such marvels have come about. 19 But you, do not think you will go unpunished, now that you have undertaken to fight against God."
20 The mother was the most remarkable of all, and deserves to be remembered with honor. She watched her seven sons die in a single day, yet she bore it bravely because of her hope in the Lord. 21 In the

language of her ancestors she encouraged each of them, filled with
a noble spirit; rousing her woman's reasoning with a man's courage,
she said to them, 22 "How you appeared within my womb I cannot
tell. Not I bestowed on you spirit and life; not I arranged in order the
elements that compose each one of you. 23 It is the world's Creator,
then, who formed humanity at its birth and found out how all things
come to be, who will give spirit and life back to you again in mercy,
since now you hold yourselves of no account on behalf of his laws."
24 Antiochus felt he was being mocked, and suspected that her words
were an insult. The youngest son was still alive, and the king not
only appealed to him with words but also gave him his sworn word
that he would make him rich and fortunate if he would abandon his
ancestors' ways, and that he would make him his Friend and give him
a high position. 25 Because the young man paid no attention at all, the
king summoned the mother and urged her to advise the boy to save
himself. 26 After he had urged her at length, she undertook to persuade
her son. 27 But she leaned close to him, scorned the cruel tyrant, and
said in her ancestral language: "My son, take pity on me. For nine
months I carried you in my womb, and for three years I nursed you;
I raised you and brought you up to this age, and I have cared for you.
28 Child, I ask you to lift your eyes to the sky and the earth, to look
at all that is in them, and to understand that God made them from
what did not exist.[c] So it is too that the human race comes to be. 29 Do
not fear this butcher, but prove worthy of your brothers and accept
death, so that in God's mercy I may receive you back along with your
brothers."
30 She was still speaking when the young man said, "For whom are you
waiting? To the king's decree I do not listen; I heed the decree of the
law given through Moses to our fathers. 31 But you, who have devised
every kind of evil against the Hebrews, will not escape God's hands.
32 For we are suffering because of our own sins. 33 And if, for the sake
of rebuke and discipline, our living Lord is angry with us for a little
while, he will be reconciled again with his own servants. 34 But you,
impious man, foulest of all mortals, do not soar up idly, swelling with
hopes that have no ground, as you lift your hand against Heaven's

children. 35 You have not yet escaped the judgment of the all-seeing, almighty God. 36 For our brothers, after enduring brief pain, have now fallen under God's covenant of ever-flowing life;[d] but you, by the judgment of God, will bear the just penalty for your arrogance. 37 Like my brothers, I surrender body and soul for our ancestral laws, and I call upon God to be quickly gracious to the nation, and through afflictions and scourges to bring you to acknowledge that he and he alone is God, 38 and that in me and my brothers the Almighty's anger, rightly kindled against all our race, may be stayed."

39 Enraged, the king treated this one more savagely than the rest, taking the mockery bitterly. 40 So he too died in purity, putting his whole trust in the Lord. 41 Last of all, after her sons, the mother died.

42 Concerning the sacrificial meals and the surpassing cruelties, then, so much has been shown.

Notes

- a (7:6) Deut 32:36; the "song" is the Song of Moses, Deut 32:1–43 (see Deut 31:19–21).
- b (7:8) That is, probably Aramaic, or Hebrew.
- c (7:28) Or "out of things that were not"; this is often cited as an early statement of creation from nothing.
- d (7:36) Or "have fallen, under God's covenant, into everlasting life." In Swete's edition verses 35 and 36 are printed together, and the following verses are numbered one lower; the standard numbering is followed here.

Chapter 8

1 Meanwhile Judas, also called Maccabeus, and those with him slipped secretly into the villages and summoned their kinsfolk; and enlisting those who had held fast to Judaism, they gathered about six thousand. 2 They called on the Lord to look upon the people oppressed by all, and to take pity on the sanctuary profaned by the godless, 3 to have mercy too on the city being ruined and about to be leveled to the ground, and to give ear to the blood that cried out to him, 4 to remember also the lawless slaughter of the innocent babes and the blasphemies uttered against his name, and to show his hatred of evil.

5 As soon as Maccabeus had his men organized, the Gentiles could no longer stand against him, because the Lord's anger had turned to

mercy. 6 Arriving unlooked for, he would burn towns and villages; he
took the favorable positions and put to flight no small number of the
enemy, 7 choosing the nights especially as his allies for such raids.
And talk of his valor resounded everywhere.
8 Philip, perceiving that the man was making headway by degrees
and advancing more and more often in success, wrote to Ptolemy,
governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, to come and reinforce the
king's cause.[a] 9 Ptolemy quickly appointed Nicanor son of Patroclus,
who was among the King's First Friends,[b] and dispatched him with
no fewer than twenty thousand troops from various nations to wipe
out the entire Judean people. Gorgias, a general with experience in
war, was joined with him. 10 Nicanor resolved to make up, by the sale
of Jewish captives, the tribute of about seventy-five tons of silver that
the king owed the Romans.[c] 11 He sent at once to the towns along the
seacoast, calling buyers to come for Jewish slaves and undertaking to
hand over ninety head for each seventy-five pounds of silver, never
anticipating the justice of the Almighty which was soon to dog his
steps.
12 Word reached Judas of Nicanor's advance; and when he told his
companions that the army was near, 13 those who were cowardly and
had no faith in God's justice ran off and took themselves elsewhere.
14 The rest sold all they had left, while at the same time they begged
the Lord to rescue those whom the impious Nicanor had sold before
he had even met them in battle, 15 and this, though not for their own
merits, at least because of the covenants made with their fathers, and
since his revered and glorious name was invoked over them.
16 Maccabeus gathered his men, about six thousand in all, and urged
them not to be terrified of the enemy or afraid of the huge crowd of
Gentiles marching unjustly against them, but to fight with courage,
17 keeping before their eyes the outrage those men had lawlessly
committed against the holy place, the torment inflicted on the humil-
iated city, and moreover the overthrow of their ancestral way of life.
18 "They trust in weapons and boldness," he said, "but we trust in
almighty God, who can strike down both those who attack us and
the whole world with a single nod." 19 Moreover he recounted to them

the times when help had come to their forefathers: how in the days of Sennacherib a hundred eighty-five thousand perished,[d] 20 and the clash in Babylonia against the Galatians, when the whole force that went into action was eight thousand together with four thousand Macedonians; the Macedonians being at a loss, the six thousand destroyed a hundred and twenty thousand through help sent them from heaven, and took much booty.[e] 21 Having made them bold by these words and willing to die on behalf of the laws and the homeland, he formed the army into four companies. 22 He set his brothers, Simon, Joseph, and Jonathan, each at the head of a division, putting fifteen hundred men under each. 23 Besides these, he appointed Eleazar to read aloud from the holy book;[f] and giving the watchword "The help of God," he himself led the first division and joined battle with Nicanor. 24 The Almighty fighting on their side, they cut down upward of nine thousand of the foe, wounded and crippled most of Nicanor's host, and drove the whole of it to flight. 25 The money of those who had come to purchase them fell into their hands. When they had chased the enemy a good way, they turned back, being hemmed in by the time. 26 It was the day before the sabbath, and so they did not continue the chase. 27 When they had collected the enemy's arms and stripped them of their spoils, they turned to keeping the sabbath, giving abundant praise and thanks to the Lord, who had preserved them for that day and had allotted it to them as the beginning of mercy. 28 After the sabbath they gave a portion of the booty to the victims of torture, the widows, and the orphans, and shared out what remained among themselves and their little ones. 29 When they had done this, they made a common supplication and implored the merciful Lord to be wholly reconciled with his servants.

30 In clashes with the forces of Timothy and Bacchides, they killed over twenty thousand and captured some very high strongholds. They divided a large amount of plunder, giving equal shares to those who had been tortured, to orphans and widows, and also to the elderly.[g] 31 They collected the enemy's weapons and carefully stored them all in key locations; the rest of the spoils they brought to Jerusalem. 32 They killed the commander of Timothy's forces,[h] a most unholy man

who had caused the Jews much grief. [33] While celebrating the victory in their homeland, they burned those who had set fire to the sacred gates, including Callisthenes, who had fled into a little house; so he received the reward his impiety deserved.

[34] The thrice-accursed Nicanor, [i] who had brought along three thousand merchants to buy the Jews, [35] was humbled, with the Lord's help, by those whom he had regarded as the least of all. He threw off his splendid uniform and made his way alone across the country like a runaway slave until he reached Antioch, having been eminently successful in the destruction of his own army. [36] And he who had taken it upon himself to pay the Romans their tribute out of the captives of Jerusalem announced that the Jews had a Champion fighting for them, and for that reason were invulnerable, since they kept the laws he had ordained.

Notes

- a (8:8) See 1 Macc 3:38–4:25 for another account of this campaign. Philip was the governor left in Jerusalem (5:22).
- b (8:9) "First Friends" was an honorary rank at the Seleucid court.
- c (8:10) Greek: two thousand talents. A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg). The tribute was imposed on Antiochus III by the Peace of Apamea (188 BC).
- d (8:19) See 2 Kings 19:35; Isa 37:36.
- e (8:20) This battle is otherwise unknown. The figures are as given in the Greek; how the six thousand relate to the eight thousand is unclear.
- f (8:23) Swete's text reads "and Eleazar" without a verb; the sense of the clause is uncertain.
- g (8:30) Some interpreters place this verse after 10:38, since the campaigns against Timothy and Bacchides are described later.
- h (8:32) Greek phylarchēs, "commander of a tribe" or "cavalry commander."
- i (8:34) Literally "thrice-sinful" or "thrice-wicked"; compare 15:3.

Chapter 9

[1] About that season it happened that Antiochus had withdrawn in disorder from the regions around Persia. [2] He had gone into the city called Persepolis[a] and tried to rob the temples and take over the city. At that, the people rushed to defend it with weapons, and Antiochus, routed by the inhabitants, retreated in disgrace. [3] While he was at Ecbatana,[b] news reached him of what had befallen Nicanor and the

forces of Timothy. 4 Swollen with rage, he planned to make the Jews
pay for the injury inflicted by those who had chased him away; so he
told his charioteer to drive without stopping until the trip was over.
Yet heaven's judgment was riding with him! For in his pride he had
said, "When I arrive there, I will turn Jerusalem into one mass grave
for the Jews."
5 But the all-seeing Lord, the God of Israel, struck him with a blow
incurable and unseen. No sooner had he finished the words than an
unrelenting pain of the bowels seized him, with bitter torments of
the inward parts, 6 most justly, since he had tormented the bowels of
others with many strange miseries. 7 Yet in no way did he cease from
his insolence; still brimming with arrogance, breathing fire in his fury
against the Jews, he gave orders to speed the journey. And it came
about that he fell from the chariot as it rushed along, and the fall was
so violent that every limb of his body was racked. 8 He who but now,
in pride beyond what is human, fancied he could give orders to the
billows of the sea and set the mountain heights upon the scales, came
down to the ground and was borne along on a stretcher, showing
openly to all the power of God. 9 So it was that worms swarmed out
of the body of the impious man, and while he still lived, in anguish
and pains, his flesh rotted away, and the whole army was burdened
by the stench of his decay. 10 The man who shortly before had seemed
to touch the stars of heaven, no one could bear to carry, because of
the intolerable weight of the stench.
11 Then at last, broken in spirit, he began to lay aside the greater
part of his arrogance and to come to knowledge under the scourge
of God, his pains increasing moment by moment. 12 And when he
could no longer bear even his own stench, he said this: "It is just to
submit to God, and that one who is mortal should not have arrogant
thoughts." 13 And the defiled wretch made a vow to the Master, who
would no longer have mercy on him, speaking thus: 14 that the holy
city, which he had been hurrying to level to the ground and turn into
a common graveyard, he would declare free; 15 that the Jews, whom
he had judged unworthy even of burial and fit only to be thrown
out with their infants as prey for birds and beasts, he would make,

all of them, equal to citizens of Athens; 16 the holy sanctuary that he had earlier stripped he would deck with the most beautiful offerings, and he would restore all the sacred vessels many times multiplied, and from his own revenues he would furnish the allowances due for the sacrifices; 17 and besides all this, that he would become a Jew and travel through every inhabited place proclaiming the might of God.
18 But when his sufferings did not ease at all, because God's just judgment had fallen on him, he gave up all hope for himself and wrote the letter given below to the Jews, in the form of a plea. It said: 19 "To the worthy Jews, the citizens: King Antiochus, the general, wishes much joy, health, and well-being. 20 If you fare well, and your children, and your private affairs go according to your mind, [I give great thanks to God,][c] having my hope in heaven. 21 [For my part, I have been sick,] and I remembered fondly your honor and good will. Returning from the districts of Persia I met with a sickness hard to bear, and I thought it needful to provide for the common safety of you all. 22 I do not despair of my condition; on the contrary, I have good hope of recovering from the illness. 23 But I observed that my father too, on the occasions when he marched into the upper countries, appointed his successor, 24 so that, if anything unexpected should occur or any unwelcome news be reported, the people throughout the realm would not be troubled, knowing to whom the government had been left. 25 Furthermore, I am aware that the princes along our borders and the neighbors of the kingdom are watching for their chance and waiting to see what happens. So I have appointed my son Antiochus as king. I often entrusted him to most of you and recommended him when I hurried off to the upper provinces. I have written to him as follows. 26 I appeal to you, then, and ask, mindful of the kindnesses done you both in common and individually, that each one preserve the good will he now holds toward me and my son. 27 For I am persuaded that he, following my policy, will treat you with moderation and kindness."
28 And so the slayer and blasphemer, having suffered the worst, even as he had dealt with others, ended his days on foreign soil in the mountains by a most wretched doom. 29 Philip, one of his courtiers,[d]

carried his body home; then, fearing Antiochus's son, he went over to Ptolemy Philometor in Egypt.

Notes

- a (9:2) Persepolis, the old capital of Persia. 1 Macc 6:1 names Elymais.
- b (9:3) Ecbatana, in Media (modern Hamadan, Iran).
- c (9:20) The Greek of vv. 20–21 appears defective; the bracketed words are supplied from the sense.
- d (9:29) Greek syntrophos, literally "one brought up with him," a court title, "foster brother" or "intimate companion."

Chapter 10

1 Now Maccabeus and those with him, the Lord leading them on, recovered the sanctuary and the city. 2 The altars erected in the marketplace by the foreigners they tore down, and the sacred precincts as well. 3 Having cleansed the shrine, they made another altar of sacrifice; and striking fire from flints and taking fire from them, they offered sacrifices after a lapse of two years, and incense and lamps, and they set out the loaves of the Presence.[a] 4 When they had done these things they fell prostrate and entreated the Lord that they might fall no more into such calamities; rather, if ever they did sin, that they be chastened by him gently and not given up to Gentiles who blaspheme and are savage. 5 It so fell out that on the very day the shrine had been profaned by foreigners, on that same day the purification of the sanctuary took place, the twenty-fifth of that same month, which is Chislev (in November–December).[b] 6 They celebrated for eight days with gladness, as at the festival of Booths, recalling that a short time earlier, at the festival of Booths, they had been living like wild animals in the mountains and caves.[c] 7 Therefore, holding ivy-wreathed wands and fair branches and palm fronds too, they offered hymns of thanks to him who had brought to good success the cleansing of his own place. 8 And by public ordinance and vote they decreed for the whole nation of the Jews that they should keep these days every year.[d]

9 Such then was the end of Antiochus, the one called Epiphanes. 10 Now we will describe what happened under Antiochus Eupator, the son of that godless man, summarizing the main evils of the wars. 11

For this man, when he came to the throne, put one Lysias in charge of the government, and made him chief governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. 12 For Ptolemy, who was called Macron,[e] had taken the lead in dealing justly with the Jews because of the wrong that had been done them, and tried to manage affairs with them peaceably. 13 So he was denounced to Eupator by the Friends and heard himself named a traitor on every hand, since he had deserted Cyprus, put in his trust by Philometor, and withdrawn to Antiochus Epiphanes; and holding his authority without honor,[f] he poisoned himself and departed this life.

14 When Gorgias became governor of the region, he kept a force of hired soldiers and took every chance to wage war against the Jews. 15 Together with him the Idumeans also, who held strongholds well placed, harassed the Jews; and receiving those who had been banished from Jerusalem, they set about keeping the war alive. 16 Maccabeus and those about him, having held a litany and asked God to be their ally, charged against the fortresses of the Idumeans. 17 Attacking them vigorously, they took possession of the places, beat off all who fought upon the wall, and slaughtered those who fell into their hands, killing no fewer than twenty thousand. 18 When at least nine thousand had fled together into two very strong towers, well furnished with everything for withstanding a siege, 19 Maccabeus left Simon and Joseph, and Zacchaeus also and his men, enough to besiege them, and went off himself to places where he was more urgently needed. 20 But those around Simon, out of love of silver, were won over with money by some of those in the towers; they took about six hundred sixty pounds of silver[g] and allowed some to escape. 21 When Maccabeus was told what had happened, he assembled the leaders of the people and charged these men with selling their own people for money by setting their enemies free to fight them. 22 Then he put these men to death as traitors, and forthwith captured the two towers. 23 Prospering in every undertaking of arms that he took in hand, he destroyed more than twenty thousand in the two strongholds.

24 Now Timothy, who had been defeated by the Jews before, gathered foreign forces in vast numbers and collected not a few of the cavalry

from Asia, and came on, intending to take Judea by the spear. 25 As
he drew near, Maccabeus and his men turned to supplication of God,
sprinkling earth on their heads and girding their loins with sackcloth.
26 Prostrating themselves on the platform facing the altar, they asked
that he become merciful to them and be hostile to those hostile to
them and oppose those who opposed them, as the law makes plain.[h]
27 Having finished the petition, they took up their weapons and went
forth farther from the city, and when they had come close to the foe,
they kept to themselves. 28 At first light the two sides joined battle; one
side had as its guarantee of success and victory not only its courage
but also its refuge in the Lord, while the other let its own rage lead
the fight.
29 As the fighting grew hard, five splendid men appeared from the
sky to the adversaries, mounted on gold-bridled horses, two of whom
were at the head of the Jews; 30 surrounded Maccabeus and, shielding
him with their armor, kept him from being wounded. Shooting
arrows and lightning bolts at the enemy, they left them bewildered
and blinded, and the enemy was cut to pieces in total confusion. 31
There fell slain twenty thousand and five hundred, and six hundred
of the cavalry.
32 Timothy for his part took refuge in Gazara,[i] as the stronghold
is called, a fortress exceedingly strong, under the command of
Chaereas. 33 Then Maccabeus and his men, in high spirits, besieged
the fortress for forty days. 34 The men within, trusting in the steepness
of the site, poured out blasphemy beyond measure and spoke lawless
words. 35 But as the twenty-fifth day was dawning,[j] young men
among the followers of Maccabeus, set aflame in their hearts by the
blasphemies, assaulted the wall manfully, and with the fury of wild
beasts hewed down whoever came in their way. 36 Others likewise
climbed up by a diversion against those within; they set the towers
on fire, and kindling fires burned the blasphemers alive. Others broke
open the gates, let in the rest of the force, and occupied the city. 37
They slew Timothy, who was hidden in a cistern, and his brother
Chaereas, and Apollophanes. 38 Having carried these things through,

they blessed the Lord with hymns and confession of praise, for he does great good to Israel and grants them the triumph.

Notes

- a (10:3) See Exod 25:30; Lev 24:5–9. 1 Macc 4:52–54 gives three years since the profanation; on Hanukkah see also 1:9, 18 and 1 Macc 4:52–59.
- b (10:5) Chislev, the ninth month (in November–December). This was the twenty-fifth of Chislev, 148 of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:7), that is, December 164 BC; compare 1 Macc 4:52. This is the origin of Hanukkah ("Dedication"); compare John 10:22.
- c (10:6) Booths (Tabernacles) was celebrated for eight days in the seventh month (Lev 23:33–43). Hence the feast of Dedication is called "Booths of Chislev" in 1:9.
- d (10:8) Swete's Greek reads "the tenth days," probably a scribal error for "these days."
- e (10:12) Ptolemy Macron; compare 1 Macc 3:38, where a Ptolemy son of Dorymenes is named.
- f (10:13) Literally "not ennobling his noble office." The Greek is obscure.
- g (10:20) Greek: seventy thousand drachmas. A drachma was about 0.15 ounce (4.3 g) of silver.
- h (10:26) See Exod 23:22.
- i (10:32) Gazara (Gezer), west of Jerusalem. Some identify the place in this story with Jazer east of the Jordan (1 Macc 5:8).
- j (10:35) Greek "the fifth and twentieth day," apparently counted from the start of the forty-day siege (v. 33).

Chapter 11

1 After a very short interval of time, Lysias, the king's steward and kinsman and head of affairs, bearing it very heavily over what had come to pass, 2 mustered about eighty thousand men and all his cavalry and marched against the Jews, expecting to turn the city into a home for Greeks, 3 levy silver from the sanctuary as from the other sacred precincts of the nations, and put up the high priesthood for sale every year. 4 He took no account whatever of the might of God, but was puffed up by his tens of thousands of foot soldiers, his thousands of horsemen, and his eighty elephants.

5 Entering Judea, he drew near to Beth-zur, a fortified place about twenty miles from Jerusalem,[a] and pressed it hard. 6 When Maccabeus and his men learned that he was besieging the strongholds, they and the crowds with them begged the Lord, with sobbing and tears, to

send a good angel to rescue Israel. 7 Maccabeus was first of all to
seize his weapons, and he called on the rest to share the danger with
him in coming to the help of their brothers; and together, with ready
hearts, they sallied forth. 8 Right there, close by Jerusalem, a rider on
horseback was seen going before them in a white garment, shaking
a panoply of gold. 9 Together they all blessed the merciful God and
were strengthened in their souls, ready to pierce not only men but
the fiercest beasts and walls of iron. 10 They advanced in battle array,
having their Ally from heaven, for the Lord had shown them mercy. 11
Charging at the enemy like lions, they struck down eleven thousand
foot soldiers and sixteen hundred horsemen, and made all the rest
run. 12 Most of them got away wounded and stripped of their arms,
and Lysias himself escaped only by shameful flight.
13 He was no fool, and thought over the defeat he had suffered, and re-
alized that the Hebrews could not be beaten, because the mighty God
fought for them. So he sent a message to them 14 and persuaded them
to come to a settlement on all just terms, promising that he would
persuade the king also, constraining him to become their friend. 15
Maccabeus, mindful of what was advantageous, nodded assent to
everything for which Lysias appealed; for all that Maccabeus handed
to Lysias in writing on behalf of the Jews, the king conceded.
16 The letters written to the Jews were as follows. That from Lysias
ran thus:

"Lysias to the people of the Jews, greeting.
17 John and Absalom, who were sent by you, delivered the communi-
cation written below and asked about the matters it set forth.
18 Whatever needed to be referred to the king as well, I have made
known to him, and what was possible he has granted.
19 If, then, you maintain your good will toward the government, I will
try in the future also to be a cause of good things for you.
20 On the details I have ordered these men and my own representatives
to confer with you.
21 Farewell. In the year one hundred forty-eight, on the twenty-fourth
of Dioscorinthius."[b]

22 The letter of the king contained the following: "King Antiochus to
Lysias his brother, greeting. 23 Since our father has been translated to
the gods, it is our will that those of the realm be left untroubled to
care for what is theirs. 24 We have heard that the Jews will not agree
to our father's transfer of them to Hellenic ways, but, choosing their
own manner of life, request that their lawful customs be conceded to
them. 25 Choosing, therefore, that this nation too should be free from
disturbance, we decide that their sanctuary be restored to them and
that they live according to the customs of their ancestors. 26 Therefore
you will do well to send word to them and give them right hands,[c] so
that, knowing our purpose, they may be in good heart and pass their
days gladly in caring for their own concerns."
27 The king's letter to the nation read as follows:
"King Antiochus greets the council of elders of the Jews and the
rest of the Jews.
28 If you are well, it would be as we wish; we too are in good health.
29 Menelaus has made it plain to us that you desire to come down and
be about your private business.
30 To those, then, who come down before the thirtieth day of Xanthicus
there shall be a right hand of peace, with freedom from fear,[d]
31 that the Jews may enjoy their own provisions and laws, as also
before; and no one of them in any manner shall be troubled over the
things done unwittingly.
32 I have also sent Menelaus to encourage you.
33 Farewell. In the year one hundred forty-eight, on the fifteenth of
Xanthicus" (in March–April).[e]
34 There was also sent to them a letter from the Romans, worded
thus: "Quintus Memmius, Titus Manius, legates of the Romans, to the
populace of the Jews, greeting.[f] 35 Concerning the things that Lysias,
kinsman of the king, conceded to you, we also are in accord. 36 Yet
regarding what he judged must be laid before the king, examine them
and send someone at once, that we may present the matter in a fitting
way for you; for we are going on toward Antioch. 37 Therefore make
haste and send some men, so that we too may know what your mind

is. 38 Fare well. In the year one hundred forty-eight, on the fifteenth of Xanthicus."

Notes

- a (11:5) Greek "about five schoinoi." The schoinos was a measure of distance of varying length. Beth-zur lay about 18 miles (29 km) south of Jerusalem.
- b (11:21) The month Dioscorinthius is otherwise unknown. The year is 148 of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:7), that is, 165/164 BC.
- c (11:26) Literally "right hands."
- d (11:30) Swete's Greek prints vv. 29 and 30 as one verse; standard English numbering is followed here.
- e (11:33) Xanthicus, a Macedonian month (in March–April). The year is 148 of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:7), that is, spring 164 BC. Since Antiochus IV was apparently still alive at this date, the letter may belong to his reign rather than to that of his son.
- f (11:34) These Roman envoys are otherwise unknown.

Chapter 12

1 These agreements having been made, Lysias went off to the king, and the Jews went about their farming. 2 But among the commanders in those parts, Timothy and Apollonius the son of Gennaeus, Hieronymus also and Demophon, and with these Nicanor the Cypriarch,[a] would not allow them to be settled and enjoy quiet.

3 And the people of Joppa carried out an impiety of this magnitude: they invited the Jews dwelling among them to go aboard boats which they had set ready, with wives and children, as though no ill will existed toward them. 4 This being by public vote of the city, and the Jews accepting, as men wishing to live peaceably and suspecting nothing, the Joppans took them out to sea and sank them, no fewer than two hundred. 5 When Judas got word of the savagery done to his countrymen, he gave orders to the men with him, 6 and calling on God, the righteous Judge, he came against the murderers of his brothers. By night he set the harbor ablaze, burned up the boats, and put to the sword those who had fled there. 7 Then, because the place was shut tight, he withdrew, intending to come again and root out the whole commonwealth of Joppa. 8 Learning that the people in Jamnia[b] too wished to deal in the same manner with the Jews who lived among them, 9 he fell upon the Jamnites by night and set fire to

the harbor with the fleet, so that the glow of the light was visible in Jerusalem, twenty-seven miles distant.[c]
10 When they had drawn off from there about a mile,[d] on their march against Timothy, Arabs attacked him, no fewer than five thousand, and five hundred horsemen. 11 A hard battle followed, and those with Judas, through help from God, won the day; and the nomads, getting the worst of it, asked Judas to give them his right hand, promising to give him livestock and to be of service to his men in other ways. 12 Judas, supposing that they would indeed be useful in many things, consented to keep peace with them; and receiving pledges, they went off to their tents.
13 He also attacked a certain city, strong, fortified with bridges[e] and surrounded by walls, inhabited by Gentiles of every kind; its name was Caspin. 14 Those within, trusting in the strength of the walls and their store of provisions, behaved with insolence toward Judas and his men, railing at them, and blaspheming besides, and speaking what is not lawful. 15 But Judas and his men called on the great Ruler of the world, who in the days of Joshua brought down Jericho without battering rams or siege machines, and they charged fiercely at the wall. 16 They took the city by the will of God and made slaughter past telling, so that the adjoining lake, a quarter of a mile broad,[f] appeared to be filled with the blood that ran into it.
17 Withdrawing from there about eighty-six miles,[g] they came through to Charax, to the Jews called Tubiani.[h] 18 Timothy they did not find in those places, for he had by then left the district without achieving anything, though in one place he had left a garrison, a very strong one. 19 Dositheus and Sosipater, two of Maccabeus's captains, marched out and destroyed those Timothy had left in the stronghold, more than ten thousand men. 20 Maccabeus, arranging the army about him in cohorts, set these men over the cohorts and hastened against Timothy, who had with him a hundred twenty thousand foot soldiers and nine thousand[i] horsemen. 21 When Timothy learned of the approach of Judas, he sent the women and the children and the rest of the baggage ahead to the place called Carnaim,[j] for the site was hard to besiege and hard to approach because of the narrowness of all the

passes. 22 But when Judas's first cohort appeared, terror came upon
the enemy, and fear, at the manifestation of him who looks upon all
things; and they rushed headlong in flight, swept this way and that,
so that often they were hurt by their own men and run through by the
points of their swords. 23 Judas pressed the pursuit with greater vigor,
stabbing the sinners, and destroyed as many as thirty thousand men.
24 Timothy himself fell into the hands of Dositheus's and Sosipater's
men. With much deceit he begged them to let him go safe, since he
held the parents of many of them and the brothers of some, who
would otherwise be shown no regard. 25 After he had given his word
many times over, binding himself to send those people back unhurt,
they released him, for their brothers' safety.
26 Then Judas went out to Carnaim and the Atergateion,[k] and slaugh-
tered twenty-five thousand persons. 27 Following the rout and ruin of
these, he took the field against Ephron as well, a strong city in which
multitudes from all peoples lived; vigorous youths, posted before the
ramparts, fought stoutly in its defense, and supplies of engines and
darts in plenty were laid up there. 28 But calling upon the Sovereign
who with might shatters the strength of enemies, they got the town
into their hands and laid low about twenty-five thousand of those
within. 29 Setting out from there, they hastened to Scythopolis,[l] which
is about sixty-nine miles[m] from Jerusalem. 30 The Jews settled there,
however, testified to the kindness the Scythopolitans had held toward
them and to their gentle dealing in seasons of ill fortune; 31 so they
gave thanks and further urged them to be kindly to the race in days to
come, and arrived at Jerusalem with the feast of Weeks drawing near.
32 After the festival called Pentecost[n] they hastened against Gorgias,
the governor of Idumea, 33 He marched forth with three thousand
infantry and four hundred cavalry. 34 When they had joined battle, it
happened that a few of the Jews fell. 35 One Dositheus, of Bacenor's
company, a strong man on horseback, laid hold of Gorgias; seizing
his military cloak he was hauling him off forcibly, eager to capture
the cursed man living, but a horseman of the Thracians rushed upon
him and severed his shoulder, and Gorgias fled away to Marisa.[o] 36 As
Esdris and his men had been fighting a long while and were worn

out, Judas called upon the Lord to show himself their ally and leader in the battle. 37 Raising in the ancestral language the battle cry with hymns, he charged unexpectedly upon Gorgias's troops and put them to flight.

38 Then Judas assembled his army and went to the town of Adullam. As the seventh day was coming on, they purified themselves according to the custom and kept the sabbath there. 39 On the next day, since it had become necessary, Judas and his men went to collect the bodies of the fallen and bring them back to be buried with their relatives in their ancestors' graves. 40 Beneath the tunics of each of the slain they discovered consecrated amulets of the Jamnian idols, from which the law keeps the Jews away; and it was evident to everyone that this was why these had fallen. 41 All of them therefore blessed the ways of the Lord, the righteous Judge, who makes hidden things manifest, 42 and they turned to prayer, asking that the sin that had been committed be completely erased. The noble Judas urged the people to keep themselves free from sin, because they had seen with their own eyes what had happened as a result of the sin of the fallen. 43 Then he made a collection, man by man, amounting to about nineteen pounds of silver,[p] and dispatched it to Jerusalem to bring forward a sin offering, doing a most fine and seemly thing in having the resurrection in view. 44 For had he not looked for those who had fallen to stand up again, praying on behalf of the dead would be needless and silly. 45 If instead he had his eye on the most beautiful gift of grace stored up for those who lie down to sleep with piety, the thought was holy and godly. Hence he made the propitiation for the dead, that they might be loosed from the sin.

Notes

- a (12:2) "Cypriarch," governor of Cyprus.
- b (12:8) Jamnia (Hebrew Jabneh, modern Yavne), near the coast south of Joppa.
- c (12:9) Greek: two hundred forty stadia. A stadion was about 607 feet (185 m).
- d (12:10) Greek: nine stadia.
- e (12:13) Greek gephyroun, perhaps "to bridge" or "with earthworks"; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (12:16) Greek: two stadia.
- g (12:17) Greek: seven hundred fifty stadia.

- h (12:17) Charax, "palisade" or "stockade," an unidentified place. The Tubiani are the Jews of Tob or Tobias (compare 1 Macc 5:13).
- i (12:20) Greek "two thousand and in addition seven thousand."
- j (12:21) Carnaim (Karnaim), in Gilead; compare 1 Macc 5:43–44.
- k (12:26) The Atergateion, a temple of the Syrian goddess Atargatis at Carnaim.
- l (12:29) Scythopolis, "city of the Scythians," the Greek name of Beth-shan.
- m (12:29) Greek: six hundred stadia.
- n (12:32) Weeks, called Pentecost ("fiftieth") because it fell fifty days after Passover (Lev 23:15–21; Deut 16:9–10).
- o (12:35) Marisa (Mareshah), in Idumea.
- p (12:43) Greek: two thousand drachmas.

Chapter 13

1 In the hundred and forty-ninth year[a] news fell upon Judas's company that Antiochus Eupator was coming with hosts upon Judea, 2 and with him Lysias, his guardian and head of the government, each having a Greek force of a hundred ten thousand foot, five thousand three hundred horse, twenty-two elephants, and three hundred chariots fitted with scythes.

3 Menelaus too joined himself to them, and with much dissembling urged Antiochus on, not for the deliverance of his homeland, but supposing that he would be set up in office. 4 But the King of kings stirred up the wrath of Antiochus against the wicked man; and when Lysias pointed out to him that this man was to blame for all the evils, he gave orders to bring him to Beroea[b] and put him to death there in the manner of that place. 5 For there is a tower in that place, seventy-five feet high,[c] full of ashes, and it has a device that turns round, falling sheer on every side into the ashes. 6 There anyone guilty of sacrilege, or who has gone to extremes in any other evil deeds, is pushed by everyone to his destruction. 7 By such a doom it fell to the lawbreaker Menelaus to die, without even receiving burial in the earth, 8 and most justly; for since he had committed many sins against the altar, whose fire and ashes were holy, in ashes he received his death.

9 The king came on, his mind fiercely set on showing the Jews worse things than any done in his father's time. 10 When Judas learned of this, he ordered the people to call on the Lord day and night, asking

that now, if ever, he would come to their aid [11] of those about to be robbed of the law, their homeland, and the holy sanctuary, and not allow the people who had just begun to revive a little to fall into the hands of the blasphemous Gentiles. [12] When they had all done this together, begging the merciful Lord with weeping and fasting and lying face down for three days without a break, Judas encouraged them and told them to be ready. [13] After a private meeting with the elders, he resolved that before the king's army could invade Judea and become masters of the city, they would go out and decide the matter by the help of God. [14] So, handing over the outcome to the world's Lord and calling on those with him to strive nobly even to death on behalf of laws, sanctuary, city, homeland, and polity, he encamped by Modein. [15] He gave his men the password "God's victory." Taking a select group of the bravest young men, he attacked the king's tent in the night and killed up to two thousand men in the camp. He also stabbed the lead elephant along with its driver.[d] [16] At last they had filled the encampment with dread and tumult, and they got away with success. [17] Day was already breaking when this was done, owing to the shelter of the Lord that aided him.

[18] The king had now experienced the boldness of the Jews, and he tried to capture their positions by cunning. [19] He advanced against Beth-zur, a strong fortress of the Jews; he was turned back; he attacked again; he was beaten. [20] Judas sent in to those within what they needed. [21] But Rhodocus, a man from the Jewish ranks, disclosed the secrets to the enemy; he was sought out, caught, and put in prison. [22] The king parleyed a second time with the people in Beth-zur; he gave pledges, received theirs, withdrew, [23] he fell upon Judas's forces, was overcome; he learned that Philip, left behind at Antioch over affairs, had gone mad;[e] he was confounded; he called on the Jews, gave way, and swore to all just terms; he was reconciled and brought a sacrifice, honored the shrine and the place, and acted kindly. [24] He received Maccabeus, and left Hegemonides as governor from Ptolemais to the territory of the Gerrenians.[f] [25] He went to Ptolemais. The people of Ptolemais were displeased with the treaty, for they were exceedingly indignant; they wanted to annul its provisions. [26] Lysias took the

public platform, made the best defense that was possible, persuaded them, calmed them, won them over, and set out for Antioch. Such was the course of the king's attack and withdrawal.

Notes

- a (13:1) That is, 149 of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:7), 164/163 BC.
- b (13:4) Beroea, the Greek name of Aleppo in Syria.
- c (13:5) Greek: fifty cubits. A cubit was about 18 inches (45 cm).
- d (13:15) Literally "the one in the house," apparently the driver in the howdah.
- e (13:23) Greek apenenoēsthai, "had lost his senses" or "had grown desperate," that is, had rebelled.
- f (13:24) Swete's Greek has "Gennerans." The place is uncertain; it may be Gerar, south of Gaza.

Chapter 14

1 Three years' time having passed, it came to the knowledge of those around Judas that Demetrius the son of Seleucus[a] had put in by way of the port at Tripolis with a powerful host and ships, 2 and had taken possession of the country, having made away with Antiochus and his guardian Lysias.

3 A certain Alcimus, high priest before, who had of his own will polluted himself in the days of the non-mingling,[b] understanding that in no way at all was there deliverance for him, nor any longer approach to the holy altar, 4 came to King Demetrius in about the year 151.[c] They presented him with a gold crown and a palm branch, along with some of the olive branches that were customarily taken from the sanctuary; and that day he said nothing more. 5 But finding an occasion to further his own folly, when he was called into council by Demetrius and asked in what disposition and purpose the Jews stood, he answered: 6 "The ones among the Jews named Hasideans,[d] at whose head goes Judas the Maccabee, nourish war and make faction, not permitting the realm to enjoy settled order. 7 Therefore I, deprived of my ancestral glory, I mean the high priesthood, have now come here, 8 in the first place out of true-hearted care for what belongs to the king, and in the second with an eye also to my own citizens; for by the folly of the men just mentioned our entire race suffers no small ill fortune. 9 Since you are acquainted with each of these matters, O king,

take thought for our country and our hard-pressed race, in keeping with the gracious kindness you show to all. [10] For as long as Judas lives, it is impossible for the state to find peace." [11] Upon his speaking thus, the other Friends, being ill-disposed toward Judas, all the faster fanned Demetrius into a blaze. [12] Promptly selecting Nicanor, once elephant-master, and proclaiming him commander over Judea, he dispatched him, [13] with orders to kill Judas himself, scatter his men, and install Alcimus as high priest of the greatest sanctuary. [14] And the Gentiles of Judea, those who had been put to flight by Judas, came mingling with Nicanor in herds, supposing that the ill fortunes and disasters of the Jews would turn out to be their own good fortune.
[15] When the Jews heard of Nicanor's coming and the onset of the Gentiles, they sprinkled earth upon themselves and prayed to him who established his own people forever and who always upholds his own portion by manifesting himself. [16] At the command of their leader, they set out at once from there and engaged them at a village called Lessau.[e] [17] Simon, the brother of Judas, had encountered Nicanor, but had been checked for a while because of the sudden consternation caused by the enemy.[f] [18] Even so, Nicanor, hearing of the manly prowess of Judas's company and the high heart they had in contests for the homeland, was somewhat wary of making the decision through blood. [19] Therefore he sent Posidonius, Theodotus, and Mattathias to give and receive pledges of friendship. [20] When the terms had been fully considered, and the leader had laid them before the people, and it was apparent that they were of one mind, they agreed to the covenant. [21] They appointed a day on which they would come together privately; and from either side a chariot went forward, and seats were placed. [22] Judas posted armed men in readiness at strategic points, lest the enemy should suddenly commit some treachery; they held the proper conference.
[23] Nicanor stayed on in Jerusalem and did nothing out of place, but dismissed the flocks of people that had gathered. [24] Judas he had before his face continually; in his soul he had grown fond of the man. [25] He exhorted him to wed and beget children; he wed, lived settled, partook of life.

26 Alcimus, however, observing the good will they bore each other,
took the articles of agreement and arrived at Demetrius's court,
saying that Nicanor held views foreign to the state's interest, for he
had designated Judas, the plotter against the kingdom, as his deputy.
27 The king, flying into a passion and goaded by the slanders of the all-
wicked man, wrote to Nicanor declaring that he took the agreement
hard, and ordering that the Maccabee be dispatched in bonds to
Antioch with speed. 28 When this message came to Nicanor, he was
troubled and grieved at the thought of annulling their agreement
when the man had done no wrong. 29 But because there was no
acting against the king, he kept watch for a favorable time to carry
it out through some ruse. 30 The Maccabee, seeing Nicanor managing
matters with him more harshly and having turned boorish in his
wonted manner of meeting, perceived that the harshness came not
from the best intent; and drawing together no small number of those
around him, he kept himself hidden from Nicanor.
31 Recognizing that the other had nobly outgeneraled him, the man
arrived at the greatest and holy temple as the priests were bringing
forward the fitting sacrifices, and ordered them to surrender the man.
32 And when with oaths they protested that they had no knowledge of
where the one sought might be, 33 he held out his right hand toward
the shrine and swore thus: "Unless you deliver Judas to me bound, I
will make this enclosure of God a plain, dig up the altar, and set up on
this spot a conspicuous temple to Dionysus." 34 With so much said he
departed. And the priests, holding out their hands to the sky, invoked
the One who at all times fights in defense of our nation, saying this:
35 "You, O Lord, who have need of nothing, were pleased that there
should be a sanctuary for your dwelling among us. 36 Now, holy Lord
of all that is hallowed, guard undefiled for ever this house, just lately
cleansed."
37 One Razis, of the elders from Jerusalem, was informed against
before Nicanor, a lover of his fellow citizens and one of excellent
report, named for his kindliness father of the Jews. 38 For in former
times, when there was no mingling with the Gentiles, he had been
accused of Judaism, and he had with all zeal risked body and life for

Judaism. [39] Nicanor, wishing to make plain the ill will he had toward the Jews, sent more than five hundred soldiers to arrest him; [40] He reckoned that by seizing that man he would work disaster upon them. [41] As the throngs were on the verge of taking the tower and were forcing the courtyard gate and calling to bring fire and kindle the doors, he, being hemmed in on all sides, set the sword beneath himself, [42] nobly choosing to die sooner than come under the hands of the sinful and be insulted in a way unworthy of his own high birth. [43] But missing the true stroke, through the haste of the struggle, and with the throngs bursting inside the doorways, he ran up bravely onto the wall and flung himself down like a man upon the throngs. [44] They hastily stepping back and a gap being made, he came down in the middle of the open place. [45] Breath was yet in him, and burning in his spirit he got up, his blood pouring out in streams and his wounds grievous, ran through the throngs, and took his stand on a sheer rock; [46] already all but bloodless, he flung out his bowels, and seizing them in both hands he hurled them upon the throngs; and appealing to the Ruler of life and breath to give these same back to him once more, in this way he passed from life.

Notes

- a (14:1) Demetrius I Soter (reigned 162–150 BC), son of Seleucus IV; compare 1 Macc 7:1–4.
- b (14:3) Greek amixia, "non-mixing," that is, the time when Jews refused to mingle with Gentiles; also in v. 38.
- c (14:4) That is, 151 of the Seleucid era (see note on 1:7), 162/161 BC.
- d (14:6) Hasideans, from Hebrew ḥasidim, "faithful ones" or "pious ones"; compare 1 Macc 2:42; 7:13.
- e (14:16) Lessau: so Swete's Greek; many editions and translations read "Dessau." The place is otherwise unknown.
- f (14:17) The Greek of this verse is obscure; "consternation" renders aphasia, literally "speechlessness."

Chapter 15

[1] Nicanor, getting word that Judas's company were in the districts around Samaria, made up his mind to fall upon them, with complete safety, on the day of rest. [2] And when the Jews who were following him under compulsion said, "By no means destroy them so fiercely

and barbarously, but give glory to the day honored in holiness above others by him who watches over all things," [3] the thrice-wicked man asked whether there was a Sovereign in heaven who had ordered the keeping of the sabbath day. [4] When they declared, "It is the living Lord himself, Sovereign in heaven, who bade us observe the seventh day," [5] the other replied, "And I rule on earth, and I order you to pick up weapons and carry out the king's business." Even so, he did not succeed in carrying out his cruel plan.

[6] So Nicanor, holding his neck high in all his boastfulness, had resolved to set up a public monument of victory over Judas's company. [7] But Maccabeus did not cease to trust, with all hope, that he would obtain help from the Lord. [8] He exhorted those with him not to dread the onset of the Gentiles, but to keep in mind the aids that had come to them before from heaven, and now to look for the victory that would be theirs from the Almighty. [9] He encouraged them from the Law and the Prophets and reminded them of the battles they had already won, making them more eager. [10] And having roused their spirits, he gave his orders, at the same time pointing out the faithlessness of the Gentiles and their violation of oaths. [11] He equipped each of them not so much with the protection of shields and spears as with the encouragement of good words; and he cheered them all by telling a reliable dream, a kind of vision seen while awake.[a]

[12] What he saw was this: Onias, the former high priest, a good and noble man, modest in manner and gentle in character, fitting in his speech and trained from childhood in everything that belongs to virtue, with his hands stretched out, was praying for the entire Jewish community. [13] After this in the same way there appeared a man surpassing in white hair and glory, and the eminence surrounding him was a thing of wonder and utmost majesty. [14] And Onias spoke, saying, "This is a lover of the brothers, who prays much for the people and the holy city, Jeremiah the prophet of God." [15] Jeremiah stretched out his right hand and gave to Judas a sword of gold, and as he gave it he addressed him thus: [16] "Take this holy sword, a gift from God, with which you will shatter the adversaries."

17 Encouraged by the words of Judas, so noble and able to rouse to
valor and to make the souls of the young manly, they resolved not
to stay in camp[b] but to charge gallantly and, closing with the enemy
with all courage, to decide the matter, because the city and the holy
things and the sanctuary were in danger. 18 Their fear for wives and
children, and also for brothers and kindred, lay with them in the lesser
place; greatest and first was the fear for the consecrated shrine. 19 And
those left behind in the city felt no slight anguish, troubled over the
encounter in the open country.
20 When all were now awaiting the coming decision, and the enemy
had already drawn near, with the army drawn up for battle, the beasts
stationed at a convenient post, and the horsemen ranged on the
wings, 21 Maccabeus, seeing the presence of the multitudes, the varied
equipment of arms, and the savagery of the beasts, stretched up his
hands toward heaven and called upon the Lord who works wonders,
knowing that it is not through arms but, as he decides, that he wins
the victory for those who are worthy. 22 And calling upon him he
spoke in this manner: "You, O Master, sent your angel in the time of
Hezekiah king of Judea, and he slew of Sennacherib's camp as many
as a hundred eighty-five thousand.[c] 23 So now, O Sovereign of the
heavens, send a good angel before us to bring dread and trembling. 24
By the greatness of your arm may those who come against your holy
people with blasphemy be struck down." With these words he ended.
25 Nicanor's men advanced with trumpets and war songs, 26 but Judas's
men met the enemy with invocation and prayers. 27 So, fighting with
their hands and praying to God with their hearts, they laid low no
fewer than thirty-five thousand, and were greatly gladdened by God's
manifestation.
28 When the fighting was over and they were returning joyfully,
they saw Nicanor lying dead in his full armor. 29 Then there was
shouting and tumult, and they blessed the Sovereign in their ancestral
language. 30 And he who was ever in body and soul the foremost
champion of his fellow citizens, he who kept the goodwill of his youth
toward his countrymen, ordered them to cut off Nicanor's head and
his arm with the shoulder and carry them to Jerusalem. 31 When he

got there and had summoned his countrymen and placed the priests in front of the altar, he sent for the men in the fortress. 32 He showed them the head of the vile Nicanor and the hand of the blasphemer, which he had stretched out boastfully against the holy house of the Almighty. 33 And cutting out the tongue of the ungodly Nicanor, he said he would give it piecemeal to the birds, and hang up the wages of his folly opposite the sanctuary. 34 And they all, looking to heaven, blessed the Lord who had manifested himself, saying, "Blessed be he who has kept his own place undefiled!" 35 He hung Nicanor's head from the fortress, a clear and unmistakable sign to everyone of the Lord's help. 36 With one common vote they all ordained that this day must on no account be let pass without distinction, but be held as a notable day, the thirteenth of the twelfth month, which in the Syrian tongue is called Adar (in February–March), one day before the day of Mordecai.[d]

37 This, then, is how matters turned out with Nicanor; and from those times the city has been held by the Hebrews. So I too will here end my account. 38 If it is well and aptly composed, that is what I myself desired; if it is poor and mediocre, that was the best I could do. 39 It is hurtful to drink wine by itself, and again water likewise; but as wine blended with water makes a pleasing and charming delight, so also the fashioning of the narrative gladdens the hearing of those who come upon the composition. And here shall be the close.

Notes

- a (15:11) Greek hypar, a waking vision as opposed to a dream; the phrase is obscure.
- b (15:17) Or "not to wage a campaign," that is, not to wait in a fortified camp.
- c (15:22) See 2 Kings 19:35; compare 8:19.
- d (15:36) Adar, the twelfth month (in February–March). "The Syrian tongue" is Aramaic. The victory over Nicanor fell in 161 BC; compare 1 Macc 7:43–49. "Mordecai's day" is Purim (Esth 9:17–22). Swete prints this verse as v. 36 with the bracketed number (37); standard English numbering is followed here.

3 Maccabees

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 Philopator,[a] learning from those who had come back of the taking
away by Antiochus[b] of the places held under him, sent word to all his
forces, infantry and cavalry, and taking along his sister Arsinoe[c] he
marched out as far as the districts near Raphia, where Antiochus's
side had pitched camp.[d] 2 But a certain Theodotus, intending to carry
out a plot, took with him the best of the Ptolemaic weapons that had
earlier been put under his command and crossed over by night to
Ptolemy's tent, as if alone to kill him and in this way to dissolve the
war. 3 But Dositheus, called the son of Drimylus, a Jew by race who
later changed his customs and became estranged from the ancestral
teachings, had led the king away and laid some insignificant man
down in the tent; and it fell to this man to receive the punishment
meant for the other. 4 A fierce battle took place, and matters were
going more strongly for Antiochus; then Arsinoe went up and down
the forces many times, and with lament and tears, her locks let
loose, she called on them to help themselves and their children and
wives boldly, promising to give each of them, if they won, two and a
half pounds of gold.[e] 5 And so it happened that the opponents were
destroyed in hand-to-hand combat, and many also were taken captive
by the spear.

6 Having prevailed over the plot, he decided to go to the neighboring
cities and encourage them. 7 By doing this, and by allotting gifts to
the sacred precincts, he made those under him of good courage.

8 When the Jews sent to him some from the council of elders[f] and from
the elders to greet him, to bring guest-gifts, and to rejoice with him
over what had happened, it came about that he was the more eager to
visit them as soon as possible. 9 Having crossed over to Jerusalem, he
sacrificed to the faithful God and rendered thanks, and did something

of what was fitting for the place. And indeed on coming into the place,
he was struck by its earnestness and decorum, [10] and marveling also
at the good order of the temple, he took it into his mind to plan to
enter the shrine. [11] When they said that this was not fitting, because
not even the members of the nation were permitted to enter, nor even
all the priests, but only the high priest, who presides over all, and
he only once a year,[g] he was in no way persuaded. [12] Even after the
law was read aloud to him, he did not stop pushing himself forward,
insisting that he had to enter: "Even if those men are denied this
honor, I am not to be." [13] And he inquired for what reason, when he
entered every sacred precinct, no one of those present had stopped
him. [14] And someone thoughtlessly said that he was wrong to make
a marvel of this very thing.[h] [15] "But since this has happened," he said,
"why should I not enter in any case, whether they wish it or not?"
[16] Then the priests in all their vestments prostrated themselves and
begged the greatest God to help in the present plight and to turn
aside the onset of the one who was wickedly attacking; and they filled
the temple with cries and tears. [17] Those who had remained behind
in the city were alarmed and rushed out, taking it that something
mysterious was happening. [18] And the maidens shut away in their
rooms burst out along with those who bore them; they strewed their
tresses with dust and crammed the broad ways with wailing and
moans. [19] Those who had lately been dressed for marriage[i] left the
bridal chambers arranged for meeting and the modesty that becomes
them, and ran about in disorder through the city. [20] Mothers and
nurses who had charge of the infants left them, one this way and
one that, some in the houses and some along the lanes, and without
turning back they thronged to the all-highest temple. [21] Many-sided
was the supplication of those who had gathered there because of
what was being unholily attempted by him. [22] With them the bolder of
the citizens would not endure his pressing on and intending to fulfill
his purpose; [23] calling out to make a rush for arms and to die boldly
for the ancestral law, they caused much roughness in the place; and
being turned back with difficulty by the aged and the elders, they
joined in the same stance of supplication. [24] Meanwhile the throng, as

before, kept on in prayer. 25 The elders around the king tried in many ways to divert his arrogant mind from the plot he had conceived. 26 But he grew bold and dismissed them all, and was already making his approach, thinking he would bring the aforesaid deed to completion. 27 Those around him, seeing these things, turned as well, joining with our people in calling on the One holding all might to defend them in what was at hand, not overlooking the lawless and arrogant deed. 28 From the dense and laboring cry of the crowds as they gathered rose an indescribable shout; 29 It seemed as if not only the human beings but even the walls and the entire ground were resounding, since everyone then was ready to exchange life for death rather than see the place made profane.

Notes

- a (1:1) Ptolemy IV Philopator, king of Egypt 221–204 BC. "Philopator" means "father-loving."
- b (1:1) Antiochus III the Great, king of the Seleucid empire 223–187 BC.
- c (1:1) Arsinoe III, sister and wife of Ptolemy IV.
- d (1:1) Raphia, on the coast southwest of Gaza; the battle was fought in 217 BC, and Ptolemy won.
- e (1:4) Greek "two minas of gold"; a mina was about 1.25 lb (570 g).
- f (1:8) Greek gerousia, the senate or council of elders.
- g (1:11) See Lev 16:2, 29–34.
- h (1:14) Or "that it was wrong to boast of this very thing"; the Greek is obscure.
- i (1:19) The Greek of this verse is obscure; the translation is approximate.

Chapter 2

1 Then the high priest Simon, facing the shrine, bent his knees, stretched out his hands in seemly order, and made a supplication of this kind:[a]

2 "Lord, Lord, King of the skies and Ruler of everything created, holy among the holy, only sovereign, all-powerful, pay attention to us, who are crushed by a godless and defiling man, bloated with arrogance and might. 3 For you are the one who created all things, and you hold sway over the universe; you are a righteous potentate, and you judge those who do anything in outrage and haughtiness. 4 You destroyed those who did wrong before, among whom were giants trusting in might and boldness, bringing upon them water beyond

measure.[b] 5 You burned up with fire and sulfur the Sodomites, workers
of arrogance, who had become notorious for their vices, and you set
them as a pattern for those coming after.[c] 6 You put the bold Pharaoh
to the proof, he who had enslaved your holy people Israel, with many
and varied punishments, and made your power known, by which you
made known your great might. 7 Him, as he gave chase with chariots
and a horde of soldiery, you flooded over with the sea's deep; yet
those who had put their trust in you, the ruler of the whole creation,
you carried across unharmed. 8 These, beholding what your hand had
wrought, sang the praise of you, the All-powerful. 9 You, O King,
when you created the boundless and immeasurable earth, chose this
city and hallowed this place for your name, though you have need
of nothing; and you glorified it with a magnificent manifestation,
establishing it for the glory of your great and honored name. 10 And
loving the house of Israel, you promised that if we should fall away
and distress should overtake us, and we should come to this place
and pray, you would hear our prayer.[d] 11 And indeed you are faithful
and true. 12 For many a time, when our forefathers were hard pressed,
you came to their aid in their low estate and delivered them out of
grievous ills. 13 see now, holy King, because of our many and great
sins we are worn down, made subject to our enemies, and slack in
our weakness. 14 And in our downfall this bold and profane man is
bent on outraging the holy place set apart on earth for the name of
your glory. 15 For your dwelling, the heaven of heaven, is unreachable
by human beings. 16 But since you were pleased to place your glory
among your people Israel, you hallowed this place. 17 Do not take
vengeance on us for the uncleanness of these men, nor call us to
account for their profanation, lest the lawless boast in their rage and
exult in the arrogance of their tongue, saying, 18 'The sanctified house
we have trodden underfoot, just as the shrines of the loathsome idols
are trodden.' 19 Wipe away our sins, scatter our errors, and make your
mercy shine forth at this hour. 20 Let your compassions overtake us
quickly, and put praises in the mouths of those who are fallen and
crushed in soul, making peace for us."

21 Thereupon God, who oversees all, the first Father, holy among
the holy ones, having heard the lawful entreaty, scourged him who
was greatly lifted up in insolence and boldness; 22 he shook him this
way and that like a reed by the wind, so that he lay on the ground
powerless, paralyzed in his limbs, unable even to speak, struck by a
just judgment. 23 Then both Friends and bodyguards, seeing the swift
punishment that had overtaken him, and fearing that he might even
lose his life, quickly dragged him out, stricken with overwhelming
fear. 24 Some time later, when he had recovered himself, he in no way
came to repentance for having been rebuked, but departed uttering
bitter threats.
25 When he had crossed over to Egypt, he increased his wickedness
through the drinking companions and comrades already mentioned,
men estranged from all justice.[e] 26 He was not content with countless
licentious deeds, but even went on to such a pitch of boldness that
he framed slanders in those places, and many of his Friends, fixing
their gaze on the king's purpose, themselves followed his will. 27 He
proposed to inflict public disgrace upon the nation: on the tower
beside the court he set up a pillar and carved an inscription: 28 "None
who do not sacrifice shall enter their sanctuaries; and all the Jews
shall be brought to a registration and the condition of slaves; those
who speak against it shall be taken by force and removed from life. 29
Those who are registered shall be branded by fire on their bodies with
the ivy leaf, the emblem of Dionysus, and shall be enrolled according
to their former restricted status."[f] 30 But in order not to appear hateful
to all, he wrote beneath: "But if any of them choose to live among
those initiated into the mysteries, these shall have equal citizenship
with the Alexandrians."
31 Now some, superficially loathing the steps to be climbed toward
the city's piety,[g] readily gave themselves up, as if they would share
in some great fame from the association to come with the king. 32 But
the greater part held firm with a noble soul and did not depart from
their piety; offering their goods in exchange for life, they fearlessly
attempted to save themselves from the registrations. 33 They were in
good hope of obtaining help, and they abhorred those who parted

from them, judged them enemies of the nation, and deprived them of common fellowship and mutual service.

Notes

- a (2:1) This verse is missing from the electronic edition of Swete's text used for this translation, though it belongs to the transmitted text; it is translated here from the Greek reflected in Brenton's version. Simon II, high priest around 219–196 BC (compare Sir 50:1–21).
- b (2:4) See Gen 6:1–7.
- c (2:5) See Gen 19:24–25.
- d (2:10) See 1 Kgs 8:33–34; 2 Chr 6:24–25.
- e (2:25) The Greek of vv. 25–26 is loosely constructed.
- f (2:29) Or "enrolled in their former restricted status"; the Greek is obscure. The registration (laographia) apparently reduced the Jews to the status of tax-paying natives.
- g (2:31) The phrase is obscure; it may mean that they were glad to abandon the hard steps of their own faith for the city's religion.

Chapter 3

1 When the impious man learned of this, he grew so furious that he was not only enraged at those in Alexandria but set himself even more harshly against those in the countryside, and ordered that all should be quickly gathered into one place and removed from life by a most cruel fate.

2 While this was being arranged, a hostile report was spread abroad against the race by men who agreed together to do harm, a pretext being given for the slander that the Jews were keeping others from their customs.[a] 3 The Jews, however, were maintaining goodwill and unswerving loyalty toward the kings; 4 but revering God and living by his law, they kept themselves separate in the matter of foods, and for this reason they appeared hateful to some. 5 Yet adorning their way of life with the good practice of righteous deeds, they had come to be well regarded by all people. 6 This good practice of the race, talked of everywhere, the foreigners took no account of at all; 7 but they kept talking of the difference in worship and foods, claiming that these people were allies neither of the king nor of his forces, but were hostile and greatly opposed to the state's affairs; and they fastened no ordinary reproach upon them.[b]

8 The Greeks in the city, who had in no way been wronged, seeing an
unexpected tumult around these people and gatherings taking place
without warning, were not strong enough to help, for the regime was
tyrannical; but they gave encouragement and were distressed, and
supposed that these things would change; 9 for so great a community,
guilty of nothing, would not be thus overlooked. 10 And already some
neighbors, friends, and business partners, drawing certain of them
aside in secret, gave pledges to protect them and to put forth every
effort for their help.
11 That man, then, puffed up by his present good fortune and not per-
ceiving the might of the supreme God, but supposing that he would
continue always in the same purpose, wrote this letter against them:
12 "King Ptolemy Philopator, to his commanders and troops through-
out Egypt and in each locality: rejoice and be well. 13 I myself am in
good health, and so are our affairs. 14 Since our campaign into Asia,
of which you yourselves know, was brought to its end as planned
through the unfailing alliance of the gods, 15 we thought it right to
nurture the nations inhabiting Coele-Syria and Phoenicia[c] not by
force of the spear but by forbearance and much humanity, gladly
doing them good. 16 And after assigning revenues in great abundance
to the shrines city by city, we were led on also to go up to Jerusalem,
to honor the temple of those accursed men who never cease from
their folly. 17 They welcomed our presence in word but falsely in
deed; for when we were eager to enter their shrine and honor it with
splendid and most beautiful offerings, 18 carried away by their ancient
arrogance, they barred us from entering, though they fell short of our
might, owing to the humanity we hold toward all people. 19 Making
their ill will toward us evident, as the only one of the nations holding
their necks high against kings and their own benefactors, they are
not willing to bear anything genuine.
20 "But we, bearing with their folly, and having come back with
victory, and on arriving in Egypt meeting all the nations with
humanity, have done as was fitting. 21 Amid these things we made
known to all our forgetfulness of wrongs toward their kinsmen, both
because of the alliance and because of the countless affairs entrusted

to them in sincerity from the beginning; and we wished to venture a change, to count them worthy of Alexandrian citizenship and to make them partakers in our perpetual rites.[d] 22 But they, taking it in the opposite sense and thrusting away the good with their inborn malice, constantly inclining toward the base, 23 not only rejected the priceless citizenship, but also abhor, by word and by silence, the few among them who are genuinely disposed toward us; at every turn they suspect that, with their most infamous way of life, they may swiftly overthrow our affairs. 24 Therefore, fully persuaded by proofs that these people bear us ill will in every way, and taking forethought lest, if some sudden disturbance should afterward arise against us, we should have these impious people as traitors at our back and barbarous enemies, 25 we have ordered that as soon as this letter arrives you are at once to send to us those who dwell among you, together with their wives and children, with insults and abuse, confined on all sides in iron bonds, for a death without remedy and infamous, fitting for enemies. 26 For when these have been punished together, we have concluded that for the remaining time our affairs will be fully established in firm order and the best condition. 27 Whoever shelters any of the Jews, from the aged down to the infant, even to those at the breast, shall with his whole house be racked to death under the most odious tortures. 28 Anyone who wishes may inform, on the terms that he shall receive the property of the one who falls under punishment, together with about nineteen pounds of silver[e] from the royal treasury, and shall be crowned with his freedom. 29 Every place where a sheltered Jew is detected at all shall be made untrodden and burned with fire, and shall be shown wholly useless to every mortal creature for all time."

30 Such was the form in which the letter was written.

Notes

- a (3:2) Or "a pretext being given by the rumor that they hindered others from keeping the laws"; the Greek is obscure.
- b (3:7) Or "they attached no small blame to them."
- c (3:15) Coele-Syria ("hollow Syria") is the region between the Lebanon ranges, and more broadly the southern Levant.

- d (3:21) Greek “of the priests always,” perhaps of the state cults; the sense is uncertain.
- e (3:28) Greek “two thousand drachmas”; a drachma was about 0.15 oz (4.3 g), so the total is about 19 lb (8.6 kg).

Chapter 4

1 Everywhere this decree arrived, a public feast was set up for the Gentiles with shouting and joy, as the hostility long since hardened in their minds was now being shown forth with boldness. 2 But among the Jews there was unspeakable mourning and an all-lamenting cry with tears, their hearts set on fire on every side with groans, as they bewailed the destruction unexpectedly and suddenly decreed against them. 3 What district or city, or what inhabited place at all, or what streets were not filled with wailing and lamentation for them? 4 For with such bitterness and pitiless soul were they sent off together by the generals in each city that, at the extraordinary punishments, even some of their enemies, setting before their eyes the common pity and reckoning the uncertain overturning of life, wept at their most miserable sending away. 5 For an old man was led along, crowned with full gray hair, whose feet, bent over from the sluggishness of age, were forced by the impetus of a violent driving to make a swift march, without any respect. 6 And young women who had just entered the bridal chamber for the partnership of life, receiving laments instead of delight, their myrrh-drenched hair fouled with dust, were led unveiled and together raised a dirge instead of wedding songs, as if torn by the claws of foreign whelps.[a] 7 Bound, in public view, they were dragged by force as far as the putting on board the ship. 8 Their husbands, nooses instead of garlands wound about their necks, in the prime of youthful age, spent the remaining days of their marriage festivities in dirges instead of feasting and youthful ease, seeing Hades already lying at their feet. 9 They were brought down, led like wild beasts under constraint of iron bonds; some were nailed by the neck to the benches of the ships, and some had their feet made fast in unbreakable fetters; 10 moreover, with the close-set planking laid over above them, so that with their eyes darkened on every side they might receive the treatment of traitors throughout the whole voyage.

11 When they had been brought to the place called Schedia[b] and the
voyage along the coast was completed, as had been decreed by the
king, he ordered them to be encamped in the hippodrome before the
city, which was of immense circuit and very well suited for making
them an example to all who went down into the city and to those from
it who set out into the country for travel abroad, so that they might
not mingle with his forces nor be counted worthy of any enclosure
at all. 12 When this had been done, he heard that their countrymen
from the city were going out in secret and frequently lamenting the
inglorious misery of their brothers. 13 Enraged, he ordered that they
too be dealt with carefully in the same way as the others, falling short
in no way of their punishment; 14 and that the whole race be registered
by name, not for the hard labor of works briefly indicated before,[c] but
that, after being racked with the outrages commanded, they should
in the end be blotted out within the time of a single day. 15 So the
registration of these people was carried out with bitter urgency and
tireless zeal, from sunrise until sunset, and it was still unfinished after
forty days.
16 The king, greatly and continually filled with joy, held banquets
before all the idols with a mind far astray from the truth and a
profane mouth, praising things dumb and unable to speak to them
or help them, while uttering improper words against God. 17 After
the aforesaid interval of time, the scribes reported to the king that
they were no longer able to carry out the registration of the Jews
because of their immeasurable multitude, 18 though most were still
in the countryside, some still assembled in their houses and some in
the place itself, since it was impossible for all the generals in Egypt.[d]
19 When he threatened them more harshly, as having been bribed to
devise their escape, it came about that he was clearly assured on this
point, 20 when they declared with proof that both the papyrus and
the writing reeds they used had already given out. 21 This was the
working of the invincible providence of him who was helping the
Jews from heaven.

Notes

- a (4:6) Or “foreign cubs”; the image is of animals tearing their prey. The Greek is obscure.
- b (4:11) Schedia was a river port on the canal linking Alexandria with the Nile, a short distance southeast of the city.
- c (4:14) The Greek of this phrase is obscure; it may refer to the forced labor mentioned in 2:28.
- d (4:18) The Greek of this verse is obscure.

Chapter 5

1 Then, calling Hermon, who was in charge of the care of the elephants, filled with heavy wrath and bile and wholly unbending, 2 he commanded him on the coming day to give all the elephants to drink with lavish handfuls of frankincense and much unmixed wine, they being five hundred in number, and, when they had been made savage by the unstinted supply of drink, to lead them in to meet the doom of the Jews. 3 Giving these orders, he turned to his feasting, gathering those of his Friends and of the army who were most hostile toward the Jews. 4 And Hermon, the master of the elephants, carried out the order punctiliously. 5 The attendants assigned to these matters went out toward evening and bound the hands of the wretched people, and contrived the other means of securing them through the night, thinking that the race would meet the end of its destruction all at once. 6 But the Jews, who seemed to the Gentiles to be bereft of all protection because of the constraint of bonds surrounding them on every side, 7 all called with tears, with a cry hard to quiet, upon the Lord Almighty, who rules over every power, their merciful God and Father, praying 8 that he would turn back the unholy design against them and rescue them, with a magnificent manifestation, from the doom lying ready at their feet. 9 So their entreaty went up fervently to heaven.

10 Hermon, having watered the merciless elephants until they were filled with the great supply of wine and sated with the frankincense, was at the court at dawn to report about these things to the king. 11 But the good creation of time, from of old cast upon night and day by him who grants it to all whom he wills, sleep, he sent a portion of to the king;[a] 12 and by the working of the Master he was held fast in

a most sweet and deep sleep, greatly thwarted in his lawless purpose and much deceived in his unbending reckoning. 13 The Jews, having slipped past the hour that had been signaled beforehand, gave praise to their holy God, and once more they besought the One quick to be reconciled to display before the haughty nations the strength of his mighty hand.

14 When it was now nearly the middle of the tenth hour,[b] the officer assigned to the invitations, seeing the guests assembled, went and nudged the king. 15 Rousing him with difficulty, he pointed out that the time of the banquet was already slipping past, giving him an account of these matters. 16 The king, considering this, turned to his drinking and ordered those who had come to the banquet to recline opposite him. 17 When this was done, he urged them to give themselves to feasting and, being highly honored, to devote the present part of the banquet to merriment. 18 As the conversation went on at length, the king called Hermon and asked with bitter threats for what reason the Jews had been allowed to survive the past day. 19 When Hermon pointed out that he had carried out the order by night, and his Friends bore witness with him, 20 the king, having a cruelty worse than that of Phalaris,[c] said that they could thank his sleep for this day; "but without delay, for the coming day, get the elephants ready in the same way for the annihilation of the lawless Jews." 21 When the king had spoken, all who were present gladly agreed together with joy, and each departed to his own house. 22 And they spent the time of night not so much in sleep as in devising every kind of mockery for those who seemed wretched.

23 The cock had just crowed at dawn when Hermon, having armed the beasts, was setting them in motion in the great colonnade. 24 The crowds throughout the city had gathered for the most pitiable spectacle, eagerly waiting for morning. 25 And the Jews, their breath being drawn out of them for the briefest time,[d] stretching their hands toward heaven in a tearful supplication with mournful strains, begged the greatest God to help them again speedily. 26 The sun's rays were not yet spreading, and while the king was receiving his Friends, Hermon stood by and summoned him to go out, pointing out that

the king's desire lay ready. 27 Receiving the report and struck with amazement at the lawless going out, being wholly overcome by lack of understanding, he asked what the matter was for which this had been completed for him with such haste.[e] 28 This was the working of God, who rules over all, who had put into his mind a forgetfulness of what he had previously devised. 29 Hermon and all the Friends pointed to the beasts and the forces: "They have been made ready, O king, in accordance with your earnest purpose." 30 But he was filled with heavy bile at these words, because by the providence of God his every thought about these matters had been scattered; and gazing intently at him he said with threats, 31 "If your parents were present, or your children's offspring, I would have prepared them as this abundant feast for the wild beasts, instead of the Jews, who are blameless toward me and have shown complete and firm loyalty to my ancestors in an outstanding way. 32 Indeed, were it not for the affection of our upbringing together and your service, you would have been deprived of life instead of them."[f] 33 Thus Hermon had to endure a threat he never looked for, full of peril; he shrank in his look and countenance. 34 And the Friends, one by one sullenly slipping away, dismissed those who had gathered, each to his own occupation. 35 And the Jews, hearing what had come from the king, praised the Lord, the God who manifests himself, the King of kings, since they had obtained this help also from him.

36 But the king, according to the same customs, set up the whole banquet again and urged the guests to turn to merriment. 37 And calling Hermon, he said with threats, "How many times must I give you orders about these very things, you most wretched man? 38 Arm the elephants now once more for tomorrow, for the annihilation of the Jews." 39 But the kinsmen reclining with him, marveling at his unstable mind, put forward the following: 40 "O king, how long will you put us to the test in this way, ordering now for the third time that they be destroyed, and again undoing by a change of mind, when it comes to the deed, what you have decided? 41 Because of this the city is in turmoil through the suspense; and being thronged with mobs it is already in danger of being plundered many times over."

42 Thereupon the king, a Phalaris in every way, filled with senselessness and counting as nothing the changes of mind that had taken place in him for the protection of the Jews, swore a most futile oath, firmly determining to send them without delay to Hades, mangled by the knees and feet of the beasts, 43 and that he would march against Judea, swiftly make it level with the ground by fire and spear, and, burning to the ground with fire their temple which was not to be trodden by us, would quickly make it empty forever of those who offer sacrifice there. 44 Then the Friends and kinsmen departed, overjoyed and confident, and posted the forces at the most suitable places of the city for keeping guard. 45 And the master of the elephants, having driven the beasts into an almost maddened state, as one may say, with most fragrant drinks of wine mixed with frankincense, and frightfully decked out with gear, 46 about dawn, when the city was already filled with countless crowds all around the hippodrome, went into the court and urged the king on to the matter at hand. 47 And he, his impious mind filled with heavy wrath, rushed out with the whole mass of the beasts, wishing with unwounded heart and with the pupils of his eyes to watch the painful and miserable destruction of those already marked out. 48 When the Jews saw the dust of the elephants going out at the gate and of the armed force following and of the crowd's march, and heard the deep-sounding din, 49 thinking that this was the last turning point of life for them, the end of their most miserable suspense, they turned to pity and laments and kissed one another, embracing their relatives and falling on their necks, parents on children and mothers on young daughters, while other women held newborn babes at their breasts, drawing their last milk. 50 Nevertheless, recalling the help that had come to them before from heaven, they flung themselves face down with one accord, and taking the infants from the breasts 51 they cried out with an exceedingly loud voice, beseeching the Sovereign of all power to have pity on them with a manifestation, now that they stood at the gates of Hades.

Notes

- a (5:11) The Greek of this verse is obscure; the sense is that God sent the king sleep.
- b (5:14) About 3:30 in the afternoon, the hours being counted from sunrise.

- c (5:20) Phalaris, tyrant of Acragas in Sicily in the sixth century BC, was proverbial for cruelty; he was said to roast his victims in a bronze bull.
- d (5:25) Or "through the moment that drew out their souls"; the Greek is obscure.
- e (5:27) The Greek of this verse is obscure.
- f (5:32) The Greek of vv. 31–32 is obscure, and the sense given is approximate.

Chapter 6

1 Then a certain Eleazar, a man of note among the Jews from the countryside, who had already reached old age and was adorned with every virtue throughout his life, restrained the elders around him from calling upon the holy God,[a] and prayed as follows:
2 "King of great power, Most High, God Almighty, who govern all creation with compassion, 3 look upon the offspring of Abraham, upon the children of sanctified Jacob, the people of your sanctified portion, perishing unjustly as strangers in a strange land. 4 Father, you destroyed Pharaoh, once the ruler of this Egypt, who abounded in chariots and was lifted up in lawless boldness and a boastful tongue, drowning him in the sea with his arrogant army, and you made the light of mercy shine on the race of Israel. 5 Sennacherib, the oppressive king of the Assyrians, exulting in his countless forces, who had already taken the whole earth under his hand by the spear and was raised up against your holy city, speaking oppressive things with pomp and boldness, you, O Master, broke, showing your might plainly to many nations. 6 The three companions in Babylonia, who willingly gave their lives to the fire so as not to serve empty things, you rescued unharmed to a hair, bedewing the fiery furnace and sending the flame on all their adversaries.[b] 7 Daniel, hurled down into the ground by the slanders of envy to be food for lions, you led up to the light unharmed.[c] 8 And Jonah, wasting away in the belly of the deep-bred sea monster, you looked upon, Father, and showed him unharmed to all his household.[d] 9 And now, you who hate insolence, abounding in mercy, judge of all, appear quickly to those of the race of Israel who are being outraged by abominable, lawless Gentiles. 10 And if our life has been entangled in ungodliness in our exile, rescue us from the hand of the enemies, and destroy us, O Master, by whatever doom you choose. 11 Let not the vain-minded bless their

vain idols for the destruction of your beloved, saying, ‘Not even their God rescued them.’ 12 But you, Eternal One, who have all strength and all dominion, look now; have mercy on us, who by the senseless insolence of lawless men are being removed from life in the manner of traitors. 13 Let the Gentiles cower today before your invincible power, O honored One, who have power to save the race of Jacob. 14 The whole multitude of infants and their parents beseech you with tears. 15 Make it known to all the nations that you stand with us, O Lord, and have not turned your countenance away from us; rather, as you declared, ‘Even while they were in their enemies’ land, I did not disregard them,’[e] so accomplish it, Lord.”

16 Just as Eleazar was ending his prayer, the king came along by the hippodrome with the beasts and all the haughtiness of his force. 17 When the Jews saw this, they cried out loudly to heaven, so that the neighboring valleys echoed with them and caused an irrepressible panic in the whole army. 18 Then the most glorious, almighty, and true God, making his holy face shine forth, opened the gates of heaven, and out of them came down two angels in glory, dreadful to look upon, plain to the sight of everyone except the Jews. 19 They stood against the force of the adversaries and filled it with confusion and cowardice, and bound them with immovable fetters. 20 Even the king’s body began to shudder, and forgetfulness seized his heavy-tempered boldness. 21 And the beasts wheeled about against the armed troops coming behind them, trampling and wiping them out.

22 Then the king’s wrath was turned to pity and tears on account of what he had devised before. 23 For when he heard the outcry and saw them all fallen face down to their destruction, he wept and angrily threatened his Friends, saying, 24 “You are usurping royal power, and have surpassed tyrants in cruelty; and even me, your benefactor, you are attempting to remove now from rule and from life, secretly devising things not to the advantage of the kingdom. 25 Who took from their homes those who faithfully held the fortresses of the country for us, and senselessly gathered each of them here? 26 Who so lawlessly surrounded with outrages those who from the beginning have excelled all nations in goodwill toward us in every way, and

who have often accepted the worst of human dangers? [27] Loose, untie their unjust bonds! Send them away in peace to their homes, asking pardon for what has been done. [28] Release the sons of the almighty, heavenly, living God, who from our ancestors' time until now has granted unhindered stability with glory to our affairs." [29] These were the things he said; and they, released in an instant, blessed their holy God and Savior, having just escaped death.

[30] Then the king, having summoned to the city the overseer of revenues, bade him furnish the Jews with wines and the rest of what was suitable for feasting for seven days, deciding that in the very place where they had expected to meet destruction they should celebrate their deliverance with all merriment. [31] Then those who were formerly reviled and near to Hades, or rather had already set foot in it, instead of a bitter and most lamentable doom held a drinking party of deliverance, and, full of joy, divided up for couches the place prepared for their fall and burial. [32] Ceasing their all-lamenting strain of dirges, they took up the song of their ancestors, praising God, the Savior of Israel and worker of wonders; and casting away all wailing and shrieking they formed dances as a sign of peaceful merriment. [33] Likewise the king also, holding a great banquet on account of these things, gave thanks unceasingly and magnificently to heaven for the unexpected deliverance that had come to them. [34] And those who had earlier assumed that they would be destroyed and become food for birds, and had registered them with joy, groaned as they clothed themselves in shame, their fire-breathing boldness utterly quenched. [35] And the Jews, as we have said before, having formed the dance just mentioned, spent the time in feasting with joyful thanksgivings and psalms. [36] And establishing a common ordinance about these things for their whole community of sojourners, for generations, they set the aforementioned days to be kept as days of merriment, not for tippling and greed, but for the salvation brought about for them by God. [37] They petitioned the king, asking for their release to their homes.

[38] Now they had been registered from the twenty-fifth of Pachon to the fourth of Epiphi (in July–August),[f] for forty days; and their destruction was set from the fifth of Epiphi to the seventh, for three days, [39]

during which the Ruler of all, magnificently manifesting his mercy, rescued them all together unscathed. 40 They feasted, being supplied with everything by the king, until the fourteenth, the day on which they made their petition for their release. 41 The king, consenting to them, wrote for them the following letter to the generals in every city, magnanimously expressing his earnest concern:

Notes

- a (6:1) Or "having bidden the elders around him to call upon the holy God"; the Greek can be taken either way.
- b (6:6) See Dan 3; Song of the Three 23–27 (Greek Dan 3:46–50).
- c (6:7) See Dan 6.
- d (6:8) See Jonah 1:17–2:10.
- e (6:15) Compare Lev 26:44.
- f (6:38) Pachon and Epiphi are the ninth and eleventh months of the Egyptian calendar. In the Ptolemaic civil calendar of about 217 BC the dates given here would fall roughly from early July to mid-August; by the later fixed Alexandrian calendar the dates would fall in May–June. The exact equivalents are uncertain.

Chapter 7

1 "King Ptolemy Philopator, to the generals in Egypt and to all who are appointed over affairs: greetings and good health. 2 We ourselves are in good health, and so are our children, the great God directing our affairs as we choose. 3 Certain of our Friends, out of malice frequently urging us, won us over to assembling the Jews under our rule into companies and chastising them, as deserters, with outlandish penalties, 4 alleging that our affairs would never be in good order, because of the ill will these people have toward the other nations, until this was accomplished. 5 They brought them down in bonds with abuse like slaves, or rather like traitors, and without any inquiry or examination tried to do away with them, having armed themselves with a cruelty more savage than the custom of the Scythians.[a] 6 But we, threatening them severely for these things, in keeping with the clemency we have toward all people, barely granted them their lives; and having come to know that the God of heaven surely shields the Jews, fighting on their side always as a father for his sons, 7 and taking into account the firm goodwill of friendship they have toward us and our ancestors, we have justly acquitted them of every charge of whatever kind. 8

We have also commanded that all return, every man, to his own property, with nobody whatever doing them any hurt or casting up to them what has unreasonably taken place. 9 Understand that should we contrive some wicked scheme against these people, or vex them in the least, it is no mortal but God Most High, master of every power, whom we shall find set against us, beyond escape, forever, to avenge these deeds. Farewell."

10 On receiving this letter, they did not hurry at once about their departure, but they requested of the king that those of the race of the Jews who had of their own accord transgressed against the holy God and the law of God should receive through them the punishment they deserved,[b] 11 alleging that men who for their stomach's sake had broken the commands of God would never be loyal to the commands of the king either. 12 He, accepting that they spoke the truth and commending them, gave them full license to destroy freely, without any royal authorization or supervision, those who had transgressed the law of God in every place under his kingdom. 13 Then, applauding him as was fitting, their priests and the whole multitude, shouting "Hallelujah,"[c] departed with joy. 14 And on the way they put to death any of their countrymen they came upon who had become defiled, and killed them as a public example. 15 On that day they killed over three hundred men, and they celebrated the day as a festival of joy, having defeated the godless. 16 But they themselves, who had held fast to God to the death and had obtained complete deliverance and release, set out from the city with shouting,[d] giving thanks with praises and melodious hymns to the God of their ancestors, the holy Savior of Israel.

17 When they had arrived at Ptolemais, called "rose-bearing" because of the character of the place,[e] where the fleet waited for them seven days in accordance with their common resolve, 18 there they held a drinking feast of deliverance, the king generously supplying them with everything needed for the journey, each one, as far as his own house. 19 And having landed in peace with fitting thanksgivings, there likewise they resolved to keep these days also as days of merriment for the time of their sojourning. 20 These they consecrated on a

pillar, and having founded a house of prayer where the drinking feast had been held, they went away unhurt, at liberty, exceedingly glad, brought safely through by land and sea and river at the king's command, each to his own home.[f] 21 And they had greater authority among their enemies than before, with honor and awe, and were not shaken at all by anyone with respect to their possessions. 22 And all of them recovered all their belongings according to the registry, so that those who held anything gave it back to them with the greatest fear, the great God having done great deeds perfectly for their deliverance. 23 Blessed be the Deliverer of Israel for all time! Amen.

Notes

- a (7:5) The Scythians, nomads north of the Black Sea, were proverbial among Greeks for savagery.
- b (7:10) The Greek of this verse is awkwardly constructed.
- c (7:13) Hebrew for "Praise the LORD."
- d (7:16) Or "set out from the city of the shouting"; the Greek is obscure.
- e (7:17) Ptolemais here is probably a town on the Nile in the Arsinoite district (the Fayum), not the coastal city in Palestine.
- f (7:20) The Greek text followed here breaks off after "each to his"; the words "own home" are supplied from the sense, and the opening of v. 21 is likewise incomplete.

4 Maccabees

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 Since I am about to set forth a most philosophical argument, namely whether devout reason[a] is sole master of the passions, I would rightly advise you to pay earnest attention to the philosophy. 2 For the argument is necessary to everyone for knowledge, and besides it includes the praise of the greatest virtue, I mean practical wisdom.[b] 3 If, then, reason is seen to prevail over the passions that hinder self-control, namely gluttony and desire, 4 it is shown also to rule over the passions that obstruct justice, such as malice, and over those that obstruct courage, namely anger, pain, and fear. 5 How then, some might perhaps say, if reason masters the passions, does it not rule over forgetfulness and ignorance? They are attempting a ridiculous argument. 6 For reason does not master its own passions, but those that are opposed to justice, courage, self-control, and practical wisdom; and it masters these not so as to destroy them, but so as not to give way to them.

7 I could demonstrate to you from many and various sources that devout reason is absolute ruler over the passions, 8 but I can prove it far more from the manly virtue of those who perished on virtue's behalf, Eleazar and the seven brothers and the mother of these. 9 For all of these, by despising sufferings even to death, demonstrated that reason has the mastery over the passions. 10 For their virtues, then, it falls to me to praise those men who at this season died, together with their mother, for the sake of nobility and goodness; and for their honors I would count them blessed. 11 For they were admired not only by all people for their courage and endurance, but even by those who tortured them; and they became the cause of the tyranny over the nation being brought down, conquering the tyrant by their endurance, so that through them their homeland was purified. 12 But I

may speak of this shortly, after beginning with the general thesis, as I am accustomed to do; then I will turn to the account of them, giving glory to the all-wise God.

13 Our inquiry, then, is whether reason is absolute ruler over the passions. 14 Let us determine just what reason is, and what passion is, and how many kinds of passions there are, and whether reason prevails over all of them. 15 Reason, then, is the mind that, together with right living, prefers the word of wisdom.[c] 16 And wisdom is knowledge of divine and human matters and of their causes. 17 This wisdom, in turn, is the training of the law, by which we learn divine things reverently and human things to our advantage.[d] 18 The forms of wisdom are practical wisdom, justice, courage, and self-control. 19 Practical wisdom is the most authoritative of all of these, for through it reason prevails over the passions. 20 Of the passions, the two most comprehensive kinds are pleasure and pain; and each of these by nature has its seat also in the soul. 21 There are many trains of passions that follow pleasure and pain. 22 Before pleasure comes desire, and after pleasure, joy. 23 Before pain comes fear, and after pain, sorrow. 24 Anger is a passion common to pleasure and pain, if one reflects on when it has come upon him. 25 In pleasure there is also the malicious disposition, which is the most varied of all the passions. 26 In the soul it shows itself as boastfulness, love of money, love of glory, contentiousness, and envy; 27 in the body as eating everything, gluttony, and eating alone.[e] 28 So then, since pleasure and pain are as it were two plants of body and soul, these passions have many side shoots, 29 Each of these reason, the master gardener, cleanses all around, prunes, binds up, waters, and transplants in every way, and so tames the jungle of habits and passions.

30 For reason is the guide of the virtues but the absolute ruler of the passions. Observe, then, first of all through the deeds that hinder self-control, that reason is sole master of the passions. 31 Self-control, then, is mastery over the desires. 32 Of the desires, some are of the soul and some of the body, and reason evidently prevails over both. 33 Otherwise, how is it that when forbidden foods tempt us, we reject the pleasure they would give? Is it not because reason can overpower

the appetites? I believe so. 34 Accordingly, when we desire creatures of the water, birds, and four-footed animals, and every sort of food forbidden to us under the law, we abstain because of the mastery of reason. 35 For the passions of the appetites are restrained, checked by the self-controlled mind, and every motion of the body is reined in by reason.[f]

Notes

- a (1:1) Or "pious reason"; Greek eusebēs logismos, the theme of the whole book.
- b (1:2) Greek phronēsis, the virtue of sound practical judgment.
- c (1:15) Or "that prefers, with right living, the reasoning of wisdom." The definitions in vv. 15–18 draw on Stoic philosophy.
- d (1:17) Swete prints vv. 16–17 as one verse.
- e (1:27) Greek monophagia, apparently selfish eating apart from others; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (1:35) Greek "are made to strive for honor," apparently meaning "are reined in"; the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 2

1 And what wonder is it if the desires of the soul for union with beauty are rendered powerless? 2 It is for this, at any rate, that the self-controlled Joseph[a] is praised, because by reason, with his mind, he gained the mastery over sensual pleasure. 3 For though he was young and at the peak of desire for intercourse, by reason he nullified the frenzy of his passions. 4 And reason is shown to prevail not only over the frenzied goading of sensual pleasure, but over every desire. 5 Thus the law says, "You shall not desire your neighbor's wife, nor anything that belongs to your neighbor."[b] 6 And indeed, since the law has told us not to desire, I could much more readily persuade you that reason is able to master the desires, just as it masters the passions that hinder justice. 7 Otherwise, how is someone who is by habit a solitary eater, a glutton, and a drunkard re-educated, unless it is clear that reason is lord of the passions? 8 So, as soon as a person orders his life by the law, even if he is a lover of money, he forces his own character, lending without interest to those in need and canceling the debt when the seventh years arrive.[c] 9 And if someone is stingy, he is overruled by the law because of reason, so that he neither gleans his harvest fields

nor gathers the last grapes from his vineyards.[d] And in the other cases too one can recognize that it is reason that masters the passions. [10] For the law prevails even over affection toward parents, so that virtue is not betrayed for their sake; [11] it gains the upper hand over affection for a wife, convicting her when she breaks the law; [12] it rules over love for children, so that one punishes them for wrongdoing; and it masters intimacy with friends, so that one reproves them for wickedness. [13] And do not consider it paradoxical when reason, through the law, is able to prevail even over enmity, [14] so that one does not cut down the cultivated trees of the enemy, but rescues the property of foes for those who lost it, and helps raise up what has fallen.[e]

[15] Reason is shown to master the more violent passions as well: love of power, vainglory, boastfulness, arrogance, and envy. [16] For the self-controlled mind thrusts away all these malicious passions, as it does anger also; for it is master even over this. [17] Moses, indeed, when he was angered against Dathan and Abiram, did nothing against them in anger, but settled his anger by reason.[f] [18] For the self-controlled mind is able, as I said, to win the prize of valor over the passions, altering some of them and rendering others powerless. [19] Why else does our all-wise father Jacob[g] blame the households of Simeon and Levi for slaughtering the Shechemites as a whole tribe without reason, saying, "Cursed be their anger"?[h] [20] For if reason were not able to master anger, he would not have spoken so. [21] For when God fashioned the human being, he planted around him his passions and his inclinations; [22] and at that time he enthroned the mind, the sacred guide, over all, by means of the senses; [23] and to the mind he gave the law, by living according to which it will reign over a kingdom that is self-controlled, just, good, and courageous.

[24] How then, someone might say, if reason masters the passions, does it not master forgetfulness and ignorance?[i]

Notes

- a (2:2) "Joseph" means "may he add" (Gen 30:24). See Gen 39:7–12.
- b (2:5) Exod 20:17; Deut 5:21.
- c (2:8) See Exod 22:25; Lev 25:35–37; Deut 15:1–2.
- d (2:9) See Lev 19:9–10; 23:22; Deut 24:19–21.

- e (2:14) See Deut 20:19–20; Exod 23:4–5. The Greek of this verse is compressed and its construction uncertain.
- f (2:17) Num 16. “Dathan” may mean “belonging to a fountain” and “Abiram” “my father is exalted”; both meanings are uncertain.
- g (2:19) “Jacob” is popularly explained as “he grasps the heel” or “he supplants” (Gen 25:26; 27:36).
- h (2:19) Gen 34; 49:7. “Simeon” is associated with “hearing” and “Levi” with “joined” (Gen 29:33–34).
- i (2:24) This repeats the question of 1:5; the argument resumes in 3:1.

Chapter 3

1 But this argument is entirely ridiculous;[a] for reason is shown to
prevail not over its own passions, but over those of the body. 2 For
example, none of you is able to cut out desire, but reason is able to
provide that you are not enslaved to desire. 3 None of you is able to
cut anger out of the soul, but it is possible to bring aid against anger.
4 None of you is able to cut out malice, but reason can fight on your
side so that you are not bent by malice. 5 For reason is not the uprooter
of the passions, but their antagonist.
6 This can be reckoned more clearly through the thirst of King David.[b]
7 For when David had been battling the Philistines[c] all day long and,
with his nation’s soldiers, had killed many of them, 8 then, when
evening came, sweating and greatly exhausted, he came to the royal
tent, around which the whole army of our forefathers had encamped.
9 All the rest, then, were at supper. 10 But the king, being extremely
thirsty, although he had abundant springs, could not satisfy his thirst
by them. 11 Rather, an irrational desire for the water that was in the
enemy’s territory, growing ever stronger, parched him, and undoing
him, burned him up. 12 Then, when his bodyguards were complaining
over the king’s desire, two young soldiers, strong men, out of respect
for the king’s desire, armed themselves in full armor and, taking
a pitcher, climbed over the enemy’s ramparts. 13 And escaping the
notice of the guards at the gates, they went right through the whole
of the enemy camp searching. 14 And having boldly found the spring,
they filled from it the drink for the king. 15 But he, though burning
with thirst, reasoned that a drink reckoned as equal in value to blood
was a most terrible danger to his soul. 16 Therefore, setting reason

against desire, he poured out the drink as an offering to God. 17 For the self-controlled mind is able to conquer the compulsions of the passions, to quench the fires of frenzy, 18 to overcome in wrestling the pains of the body even when they are extreme, and by the nobility of reason to spurn every domination by the passions.
19 And now the occasion calls us to the demonstration from history of self-controlled reason. 20 For when our fathers enjoyed deep peace because of their observance of the law, and fared well, so that even the king of Asia, Seleucus Nicanor,[d] set apart money for them for the temple service and accepted their way of life, 21 then certain persons, rebelling against the common concord, made use of misfortunes of many kinds.

Notes

- a (3:1) Greek logismos, elsewhere "reason," here means "argument" or "line of reasoning."
- b (3:6) See 2 Sam 23:13–17; 1 Chr 11:15–19. "David" probably means "beloved."
- c (3:7) Greek "the foreigners," the usual Septuagint term for the Philistines.
- d (3:20) The king meant is probably Seleucus IV Philopator (reigned 187–175 BC; see 2 Macc 3:3); "Nicanor" ("conqueror") was properly the title of Seleucus I. The confusion is in the text.

Chapter 4

1 For a certain Simon,[a] who was a political opponent of Onias,[b] the man who at that time held the high priesthood for life, a noble and good man, after he had failed in every way to do him harm by slandering him to the nation, went off as an exile, intending to betray his homeland. 2 So he went to Apollonius, the governor of Syria, Phoenicia, and Cilicia, and told him, 3 "Since I am loyal to the king's interests, I have come to inform you that many tens of thousands in private funds are stored up in the treasuries of Jerusalem, which have no share in the temple and which properly belong to King Seleucus."
4 When Apollonius learned all the details of this, he praised Simon for his concern for the king, and going up to Seleucus he disclosed the treasure of money to him. 5 And having received authority over the matter, he came quickly into our homeland with the accursed Simon and a very heavy army 6 and said that he had come by the

king's commands to take the private funds of the treasury. [7] And when the nation protested at his word and spoke against it, thinking it utterly outrageous that those who had entrusted deposits to the temple treasury should be robbed of them, they hindered him as far as they could. [8] But Apollonius went off with threats to the temple. [9] And while the priests, with women and children, were in the temple beseeching God to shield the holy place that was being treated with contempt, [10] and while Apollonius was going up with an armed host to seize the money, there appeared from heaven angels on horseback, flashing lightning from their weapons, and casting great fear and trembling upon them. [11] Apollonius collapsed half dead in the temple's outer court, which was open to all peoples,[c] raised his hands toward heaven, and tearfully begged the Hebrews to pray for him and to placate the heavenly host. [12] For he said that he had sinned, so that he even deserved to die, and that if he were saved he would sing to all people of the blessedness of the holy place. [13] Moved by these words, Onias the high priest prayed for him, though he was also on his guard lest King Seleucus should think that Apollonius had been overthrown by human treachery and not by divine justice. [14] And he, saved beyond expectation, went off to report to the king what had happened to him.[d]

[15] When King Seleucus died, his son Antiochus Epiphanes[e] succeeded to the rule, an arrogant and terrible man, [16] who removed Onias from the high priesthood and appointed his brother Jason[f] high priest, [17] Jason having agreed that, if Antiochus would entrust the office to him, he would pay each year about 137 tons of silver.[g] [18] And he entrusted to him the high priesthood and the leadership of the nation. [19] And Jason turned the nation aside and changed its citizenship over to every kind of lawlessness, [20] so that he not only built a gymnasium on the very citadel[h] of our homeland but also abolished the care of the temple. [21] Divine justice, angered at these things, made Antiochus himself its enemy. [22] For when he was at war with Ptolemy in Egypt, and heard that a rumor had spread that he had died and that the people of Jerusalem were rejoicing exceedingly, he quickly marched back against them. [23] And when he had plundered them, he issued

a decree that if any of them were seen living by the ancestral law, they should die. 24 And when he was not able in any way to break down by his decrees the nation's devotion, but saw all his threats and punishments being set at nought, 25 so that even women, because they had circumcised their children, were thrown down from heights together with their babies, though they knew beforehand that they would suffer this,[i] 26 when, then, his decrees were despised by the people, he himself tried through tortures to compel each member of the nation to taste defiling foods and to renounce Judaism.[j]

Notes

- a (4:1) "Simon" (Hebrew Shimon) is associated with "hearing." Compare the parallel account in 2 Macc 3–4, where Simon is called captain of the temple and the governor is Apollonius, but the officer sent is Heliodorus.
- b (4:1) Onias III, high priest about 190–175 BC. The meaning of "Onias" (perhaps Hebrew Honiyah, "the LORD is gracious") is uncertain.
- c (4:11) Greek pamphylos, "of all tribes," the court open to all peoples; the exact sense is uncertain.
- d (4:14) Compare 2 Macc 3:22–40.
- e (4:15) Antiochus IV (reigned 175–164 BC). "Epiphanes" means "(god) manifest."
- f (4:16) Jason is the Greek name taken by Jeshua (Joshua), brother of Onias III; "Jason" in Greek suggests "healer." See 2 Macc 4:7–10.
- g (4:17) Greek "3,660 talents"; a talent was 75 lb (34 kg), so the sum is about 137 tons (124,000 kg). Compare 2 Macc 4:8–9.
- h (4:20) Greek akra, "height" or "citadel"; compare 2 Macc 4:12, where the gymnasium is built "under the citadel."
- i (4:25) Compare 2 Macc 6:10.
- j (4:26) Greek Ioudaismos; compare 2 Macc 2:21.

Chapter 5

1 The tyrant Antiochus, then, seated in state with his counselors on a certain high place, with his armed troops standing around him, 2 ordered the guards to drag forward each and every one of the Hebrews and to compel them to taste pork and food sacrificed to idols. 3 And should any refuse to eat what defiles, these were to be racked upon wheels and put to death. 4 When many had been seized, one, the first from the flock, a Hebrew named Eleazar,[a] a priest by descent, by learning an expert in the law, far along in years, and well known for his age to many around the tyrant, was led forward near

him. [5] And when Antiochus saw him he said, [6] "Before I begin the tortures against you, old man, I would advise you to taste the pork and save yourself; for I respect your age and your gray hairs, though having had them so long you do not seem to me to be a philosopher, since you observe the religion of the Jews. [7] For why, when nature has granted it, do you loathe eating the very fine meat of this animal? [8] It is senseless not to enjoy pleasant things that carry no disgrace, and wrong to spurn the gifts of nature. [9] And it seems to me that you will act more senselessly still if, holding vain opinions about the truth, [10] you also despise me, to your own punishment. Will you not awaken from your foolish philosophy, [11] and scatter the nonsense of your reasoning, and, taking up a mind worthy of your age, pursue the philosophy of what is truly advantageous, [12] and, bowing before my humane exhortation, have pity on your own old age? [13] Consider this: even if some power does watch over this religion of yours, it would pardon you for any offense committed under compulsion."

[14] When the tyrant was urging him in this way to the unlawful eating of meat, Eleazar asked leave to speak. [15] And receiving permission to speak, he began to address the assembly as follows: [16] "We, Antiochus, who have been persuaded to live by the divine law, consider that no compulsion is more powerful than our obedience to the law. [17] Therefore we do not consider it right to transgress the law in any way. [18] And yet, even if our law were not truly divine, as you suppose, but we only thought it divine, even so it would not be permitted us to make void our reputation for piety. [19] So do not regard it as a small sin if we should eat defiling food; [20] for to transgress the law in small things and in great is of equal weight, [21] since in either case the law is equally despised. [22] You scoff at our philosophy, as though we did not live by it with sound reason. [23] For it instructs us in self-mastery, that we may rule over every pleasure and every desire; and it drills us in courage, that we may bear every hardship of our own free will; [24] and it instructs us in justice, so that in all our conduct we act with equity; and it teaches piety, so that we worship with due reverence the only God who exists. [25] For this reason we refuse defiling food; because we trust that God established the law, we understand that the Creator of

the cosmos, in giving the law, treats us kindly in keeping with our nature. [26] What will be suited to our souls he has permitted us to eat; what will be contrary to them he has forbidden us to eat as meat. [27] It is tyrannical of you not only to compel us to transgress the law, but also to eat, so that you may deride us for this defiling food that is most hateful to us. [28] But you shall not have this laugh at my expense, [29] nor will I neglect the sacred oaths of my ancestors to keep the law, [30] no, not though you cut my eyes out and waste my inward parts away. [31] I am not so old and unmanly that my reason is not made young again by piety. [32] Against this, make ready your wheels and fan the fire more fiercely. [33] I will not so pity my own old age that I myself should break down the ancestral law. [34] I will not play you false, O law my teacher, nor will I desert you, beloved self-mastery. [35] I will not put you to shame, philosophic reason, nor will I deny you, honored priesthood and knowledge of the lawgiving. [36] You will not defile the reverend mouth of my old age, nor my lifetime lived lawfully. [37] Pure will my fathers receive me, unafraid of your compulsions even to death. [38] Over the impious you may play the tyrant; but over my reasonings on piety you will be master neither by words nor by deeds."

Notes

- a (5:4) "Eleazar" means "God has helped." Compare 2 Macc 6:18–31, where he is called a scribe.

Chapter 6

[1] When he had answered the tyrant's exhortations in this way, the guards standing by dragged Eleazar roughly to the instruments of torture. [2] And first they stripped the old man, who was adorned with the dignity of his piety. [3] Then, tying his arms behind him on each side, they flogged him with whips, [4] while a herald on the other side shouted, "Obey the king's commands!" [5] But the great-souled Eleazar, truly noble, as though being tortured in a dream, was in no way turned aside. [6] Instead, with his eyes lifted high to heaven, the old man had his flesh torn by the whips, and he streamed with blood, and his sides were wounded through. [7] And dropping to the earth, since his body could no longer bear the agonies, he still held his reason

erect and unbowed. [8] Then one of the cruel guards leaped upon him and kicked him in the flank to make him get up when he fell. [9] But he endured the pains, scorned the compulsion, and held out under the abuses; [10] and like a noble athlete taking blows, the old man was victorious over his torturers. [11] Indeed, with his face sweating and gasping heavily, he was admired even by the torturers themselves for his good fortune.[a] [12] So, partly out of pity for his old age, [13] partly from sympathy, because they knew him, and partly from admiration at his endurance, some of the king's men approached him and said, [14] "Why do you destroy yourself so unreasonably by these evils, Eleazar? [15] We will set before you some of the cooked dishes; you pretend to taste the pork, and save yourself."

[16] And Eleazar, as though tortured more bitterly by the advice, cried out, [17] "May we, the children of Abraham,[b] never think so basely that through weakness of soul we would act out a play unbecoming to us! [18] For it would be irrational, if after living our life in accordance with truth up to old age, and lawfully guarding our reputation for it, we should now change course, [19] and should ourselves become a pattern of impiety to the young, so as to become an example of eating defiling food. [20] It would be shameful if we should live on for a little while, and during that time be ridiculed by all for cowardice, [21] and be despised by the tyrant as unmanly, and not defend our divine law to the death. [22] Therefore, children of Abraham, die nobly for piety's sake! [23] And you, guards of the tyrant, why do you delay?"

[24] Seeing him so high-minded in the face of the compulsions, and not changed even by their own pity, they led him to the fire. [25] There they burned him with cruelly contrived instruments, threw him down, and poured foul-smelling liquids into his nostrils. [26] And when he was already burned to the bones and about to faint, he lifted up his eyes to God and said, [27] "You know, God, that I could be saved, yet I am dying in fiery torment for the sake of the law. [28] Be gracious to your nation, being content with the penalty we pay on their behalf. [29] Let my blood be a cleansing for them, and receive my soul as a ransom-life for theirs."[c] [30] And having said this, the holy man died nobly in his

tortures, and even in the tortures of death he resisted by reason for the sake of the law.

31 Admittedly, then, devout reason is master of the passions. 32 For if the passions had prevailed over reason, I would have rendered to them the testimony of their mastery. 33 But now, since reason has conquered the passions, we fittingly assign to it the authority of leadership. 34 And it is right for us to acknowledge that the power belongs to reason, since it masters even external pains,[d] 35 for it would be ridiculous to deny it. And I prove that reason has not only mastered pains, but also masters pleasures and does not yield to them.

Notes

- a (6:11) Greek eutychia, "good fortune" or "success"; the sense here is obscure.
- b (6:17) "Abraham" is explained as "father of a multitude" (Gen 17:5).
- c (6:29) Greek antipsychon, "a ransom" or "a substitute life"; compare 17:21–22.
- d (6:34) Swete numbers v. 35 separately with a mark; the division of vv. 34–35 follows the standard English verses.

Chapter 7

1 For like a most excellent helmsman, the reason of our father Eleazar steered the ship of piety on the sea of the passions, 2 and though buffeted by the tyrant's threats and swamped by the towering waves of the tortures, 3 in no way did it turn aside the rudders of piety until it sailed into the harbor of victory over death. 4 No city besieged with many and varied engines ever held out as did that all-holy man. Though his sacred soul was set ablaze with tortures and racks, he moved his besiegers to defeat[a] through the reason that shields piety. 5 For father Eleazar, stretching out his mind like a sheer cliff, broke the raging waves of the passions.

6 O priest worthy of the priesthood, you did not defile your sacred teeth, nor did you let your stomach, which had room only for godliness and purity, share in defiling food. 7 O you who are in accord with the law, lover of wisdom in a godly life! 8 Such ought to be those who practice the law with their own blood,[b] and who defend it with noble sweat through sufferings even to death. 9 You, father, by your endurance confirmed our loyalty to the law so that it was glorified; you did not set aside the holiness you had spoken of with reverence;

and by your deeds you made the words of philosophy trustworthy. [10] O aged man more powerful than tortures, elder more vigorous than fire, greatest king over the passions, Eleazar!

[11] For as father Aaron,[c] fully equipped with the censer, hastened through the multitude of the nation and overcame the angel who brought burning,[d] [12] so Eleazar, the descendant of Aaron, though melted down by the fire, was not turned aside in his reason. [13] And yet, most wonderful of all, though he was an old man, with the strength of his body already spent, his flesh slackened all around, and his sinews worn out, he became young again [14] in spirit through reason, and with an Isaac-like[e] reasoning he made the many-headed rack of no effect. [15] O blessed old age, reverend gray head, and lawful life, which the faithful seal of death brought to perfection!

[16] If, then, an old man despised tortures even to death for piety's sake, admittedly devout reason is the leader of the passions. [17] But perhaps some might say, "Not all prevail over the passions, because not all have prudent reason."[f] [18] But those who give thought to piety with their whole heart, they alone are able to master the passions of the flesh, [19] since they believe that to God they do not die, as our patriarchs Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob did not, but they live to God. [20] There is no contradiction, then, in the fact that some appear to be ruled by passions because of weak reason. [21] For who, living as a philosopher devoutly by the whole rule of philosophy, and having trusted in God, [22] and knowing that it is blessed to endure every pain for the sake of virtue, would not prevail over the passions through piety? [23] For only the wise and self-controlled man is courageous and lord of the passions.[g]

Notes

- a (7:4) Greek "he moved the besiegers"; the sense of the verb here is uncertain.
- b (7:8) Or "who make the law their craft with their own blood"; the Greek is unusual.
- c (7:11) The meaning of "Aaron" is uncertain.
- d (7:11) See Num 16:46–48 (Hebrew 17:11–13). Wisdom 18:21–25 also describes Aaron's victory over "the destroyer."
- e (7:14) "Isaac" means "he laughs" (Gen 21:6). The allusion is to Isaac's willingness to be sacrificed (Gen 22).

- f (7:17) Swete prints vv. 16–17 as one verse.
- g (7:23) Or "For only the wise and self-controlled man is courageous and master of the passions." Swete numbers the next sentence as 7:24; here it is 8:1, following the standard English verses.

Chapter 8

1 For this reason, at any rate, even mere youths, living as philosophers by the reason of piety, prevailed over still harsher instruments of torture.[a]

2 For when the tyrant had been conspicuously defeated in his first attempt, being unable to compel an old man to eat defiling food, then, in a violent passion, he ordered others from among the young men of the Hebrews to be brought; and if they would eat defiling food, they were to be released once they had eaten, but if they refused, they were to be tortured more cruelly.[b] 3 When the tyrant had given these orders, seven brothers were brought in together with their aged mother, handsome, modest, noble, and accomplished in every way. 4 When the tyrant saw them encircling their mother in the middle as though in a choral dance, he was pleased with them; and struck by their comeliness and their noble bearing, he smiled at them, called them near, and said, 5 "Young men, I admire with goodwill the beauty of each one of you; and since I hold in very high honor so large a number of brothers, I not only advise you not to be seized by the same madness as the old man who was tortured before you, 6 but I also urge you to yield to me and enjoy my friendship. For as I have power to chastise any who disregard my commands, so I have power to do good to any who heed me. 7 Believe me, then, and you will be given posts of authority in my service, if you will abandon the traditional rule of your way of life; 8 and sharing in the Greek way of life and changing your manner of living, take delight in your youth. 9 For if you provoke me by disobeying, you will force me to destroy every one of you with dreadful punishments and tortures. 10 So take pity on yourselves, for even I, your enemy, feel compassion for your youth and good looks. 11 Will you not consider this, that nothing awaits you if you disobey except to die on the rack?"

12 As he said these things, he ordered the instruments of torture to be
set out in front of them, so that through fear too he might persuade
them to eat defiling food. 13 When the guards had set out wheels
and joint-dislocators, racks and hooks[c] and catapults[d] and cauldrons,
frying pans and thumbscrews, iron claws and wedges, and coals for
the fire, the tyrant resumed and said, 14 "Boys, be afraid; and the justice
you revere will be merciful to you for transgressions done under
compulsion."
15 But they, hearing these enticements and seeing the dreadful devices,
not only were not afraid but even answered the tyrant with philos-
ophy, and by their sound reasoning destroyed his tyranny. 16 And yet
let us reckon: if there had been some among them who were faint-
hearted and unmanly, what words would they have used? Would
they not have been these? 17 "O wretched us, and utterly senseless!
When the king is summoning us and calling us to benefits, should
we not obey him? 18 Why do we cheer ourselves with empty wishes
and venture on a disobedience that brings death? 19 Shall we not fear,
brothers, the instruments of torture, and weigh the threats of the tor-
tures, and flee this vainglory and ruinous boastfulness? 20 Let us have
pity on our own youth, and have compassion on our mother's old
age; 21 and let us consider that if we disobey we shall die. 22 Even divine
justice will pardon us if we fear the king under compulsion. 23 Why
do we take ourselves out of this most pleasant life and rob ourselves
of this sweet world? 24 Let us not struggle against compulsion, nor be
vainglorious over our own racking. 25 Not even the law itself would of
its own will slay us for being frightened at the racks. 26 Why has such
contentiousness become fixed in us, and why does a death-bringing
endurance please us, when we might live in tranquility by obeying
the king?" 27 But the young men, though about to be tortured, said
none of these things, nor did they even consider them. 28 For they
were contemptuous of the passions and absolute rulers over pains. 29
Accordingly, the moment the tyrant stopped urging them to eat what
defiles, all of them at once with a single voice, as if from one soul,
declared:

Notes

- a (8:1) Swete numbers this verse 7:24.
- b (8:2) Swete divides this verse into two (8:1–2).
- c (8:13) Greek trochantēres; the exact nature of this device is uncertain.
- d (8:13) Greek katapeltai, probably some machine for stretching or crushing; the meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 9

1 "Tyrant, what are you waiting for? We stand prepared to perish sooner than break the commands handed down by our fathers. 2 For we would rightly be ashamed before our forebears if we did not make use of obedience to the law and of knowledge as our counselor. 3 Tyrant, counselor of lawlessness, do not, while hating us, pity us more than they do.[a] 4 For we consider your mercy, which offers us safety at the price of breaking the law, to be harder than death itself. 5 You try to frighten us by threatening us with death through tortures, as though you had not learned from Eleazar a short while ago. 6 And if the old men of the Hebrews died for piety's sake after enduring tortures too, we the young would more fittingly die, scorning the tortures of your compulsions, which our aged teacher also conquered. 7 Make the attempt, then, tyrant; and if you put us to death for piety's sake, do not suppose that you harm us by torturing us. 8 For we, through this ill-treatment and endurance, shall win the prizes of virtue;[b] 9 but you, for the abominable murder of us, will undergo at the hands of divine justice the eternal torment by fire that you deserve." 10 When they had said these things, the tyrant was not only angry with them as with the disobedient, but enraged as with the ungrateful. 11 So, at his command, the scourgers brought forward the eldest of them, and tearing off his tunic, they bound his hands and arms on each side with thongs. 12 When they had worn themselves out beating him with the whips, accomplishing nothing, they threw him up onto the wheel. 13 Stretched out on it, the noble youth had his limbs dislocated. 14 And as he was broken in every limb, he denounced the tyrant, saying, 15 "Most abominable tyrant, enemy of heavenly justice, savage-minded, you are mistreating me in this way not because I have murdered anyone or acted impiously, but because I defend the divine law." 16 And when the guards urged, "Consent to eat, and be set free from the

torments," [17] he said, "Your method is not so strong, you abominable servants, as to take my reason captive. Cut off my limbs, burn my flesh, and twist my joints; [18] through all the tortures I will convince you that the children of the Hebrews alone are unconquerable for the sake of virtue." [19] As he spoke thus, they heaped fire beneath him, and fanning it into flame,[c] drew the wheel still tauter. [20] The wheel was stained with blood on every side, and the heap of coals was quenched by the dripping fluids of his body, and pieces of flesh were whirling around the axles of the machine. [21] And though the framework of his bones was already melting away, the great-souled youth, a true son of Abraham, did not groan. [22] But, as though he were being transformed by fire into incorruption, he endured the racking nobly. [23] "Imitate me, brothers," he said. "Do not desert your post in my contest,[d] and do not forswear our brotherhood in courage. Fight a sacred and noble campaign for piety, [24] through which our fathers' righteous providence may show mercy to the nation and punish the accursed tyrant." [25] Having spoken so, the youth who was fit for holiness let his soul break away.[e]

[26] While all were marveling at his steadfastness of soul, the guards brought forward the one second in age to the first, and fitting on iron hands with sharp claws, they bound him to the instruments and the catapult. [27] And when, inquiring whether he would be willing to eat before being tortured, they heard his noble resolve, [28] those leopard-like beasts tore at him from the sinews with the iron hands and ripped off all the flesh as far as the chin, and the skin of his head. But he, steadfastly bearing this agony, said, [29] "How sweet is every form of death for the sake of our ancestral piety!" And he said to the tyrant, [30] "Most savage of all tyrants, does it not seem to you that you suffer worse torment than I, beholding the haughty calculation of your tyranny overcome by our endurance on behalf of piety? [31] For I lighten my pain by the pleasures that come through virtue, [32] but you are tortured by the threats that come with impiety. And you will not escape, most abominable tyrant, the judgments of divine wrath."

Notes

- a (9:3) Greek “do not, hating us, pity us beyond them”; the sense is obscure. “They” may be the forebears of v. 2.
- b (9:8) Or “shall carry off the prizes of virtue,” an athletic image.
- c (9:19) Or “goading”; the Greek is uncertain.
- d (9:23) Greek “do not desert my lifetime” or “my eternity”; the sense is uncertain.
- e (9:25) Literally “broke off his soul.”

Chapter 10

1 When he too had endured his celebrated death, the third was led forward, being earnestly urged by many to taste the food and save himself. 2 But he shouted out, “Are you ignorant that one and the same father sired both me and the dead, that one mother gave us birth, and that I was reared in the same doctrines? 3 I do not forswear the noble kinship of my brotherhood. 4 Therefore, if you have any instrument of punishment, apply it to my body; for my soul you cannot touch, not even if you wish to.” 5 But they, taking the man’s boldness of speech bitterly, dislocated his hands and feet with joint-dislocating instruments, and prying his limbs out of their sockets with levers, they dismembered him; 6 and they wrenched his fingers, his arms, his legs, and his elbows. 7 And when they were in no way able to strangle his spirit,[a] they tore off his skin, together with the very tips of his fingers, scalping him in the Scythian fashion,[b] and at once led him to the wheel. 8 Upon it, with his backbone wrenched apart joint from joint, he beheld his flesh shredded all about, and drops of blood streaming down out of his bowels. 9 And as he was about to die, he said, 10 “We, most abominable tyrant, are suffering these things for the sake of our godly training and virtue;[c] 11 whereas you, on account of your ungodliness and your thirst for blood, shall bear torments that never come to an end.”

12 And once this one too had died as befitted a brother, they hauled up the fourth, telling him, 13 “Do not you also be seized by the same madness as your brothers, but obey the king and save yourself.” 14 But he answered them, “The fire you hold against me is not so scorching that I should play the coward. 15 I swear by my brothers’ blessed death, by the tyrant’s everlasting ruin, and by the famous life of the godly: I will not disown our noble brotherhood. 16 Devise tortures, tyrant, so

that through them also you may learn that I am a brother of those who were tortured before me." [17] Hearing this, Antiochus, that devourer of blood, that killer, that most loathsome of men, commanded that his tongue be cut out. [18] But he said, "Even if you take away the organ of speech, God hears also those who are silent. [19] See, my tongue is stretched out; cut it, for you will not by this cut out the tongue of our reason. [20] Gladly, for God's sake, we let the limbs of our body be mutilated. [21] But God will swiftly pursue you, for you are cutting out a tongue that sang melodies of divine hymns."

Notes

- a (10:7) Greek "to strangle him"; the object is probably his resolve, but the sense is uncertain.
- b (10:7) Greek apeskythizon, "they scalped," a practice associated with the Scythians.
- c (10:10) Or "for the sake of the training and virtue of God."

Chapter 11

[1] When this one also, savagely abused by the tortures, had died in them, the fifth leaped forward, saying, [2] "Tyrant, I have no intention of begging off from torture on virtue's behalf. [3] I have come forward of my own accord, so that by killing me too you may owe to heavenly justice a penalty for a still greater number of wrongs. [4] You hater of virtue and hater of humankind, for what deed of ours are you ravaging us like this? [5] Does it seem evil to you that we revere the Creator of all things and live according to his virtuous law? [6] But these things deserve honors, not tortures, [7] if only you had perception of human longing and had hope of salvation from God.[a] [8] But as it is, being estranged from God, you make war on those who are devout toward God."

[9] As he spoke such words, the guards bound him and hauled him to the catapult. [10] Tying him to it at the knees and fastening them with iron fetters, they bent his loins back over the wheel's wedge; and around it he was entirely curled back like a scorpion upon the wheel, and torn limb from limb. [11] In this manner, cramped in his breathing and choked in his body, [12] he said, "Fine favors, tyrant, fine favors you

grant us against your will, giving us the chance, through still nobler sufferings, to display our endurance for the law."
13 When this one too had died, the sixth, a mere boy, was brought. When the tyrant inquired whether he would like to eat and be set free, he said, 14 "In years I am younger than my brothers, but in understanding I am their equal in age. 15 For since we were born and raised for the same ends, we are bound to die for the same causes likewise. 16 So if you have decided to torture those who refuse defiling food, then torture!" 17 Once he had spoken so, they brought him over to the wheel. 18 Stretched out on it carefully, limb by limb, and with his spine pulled apart, he was roasted from beneath. 19 And heating sharp spits red-hot, they applied them to his back; and piercing his sides, they burned his entrails through. 20 And while being tortured he said, "O contest fit for holy men, to which so many of us brothers have been summoned for piety's sake to a training ground of pains, and we have not been conquered! 21 For devout knowledge, tyrant, cannot be conquered. 22 Armed with nobility, I too shall die with my brothers, 23 and I myself shall bring down a mighty avenging spirit on you, you deviser of novel torments, foe of all who are genuinely godly. 24 We six boys have brought your tyranny to nothing. 25 For is not your failure to change our reasoning, or to force us to eat defiling food, your overthrow? 26 Your fire is cold to us, your catapults cause us no pain, and your violence is powerless. 27 For it is not a tyrant's but the divine law's guards that stand over us;[b] therefore our reason is unconquered."

Notes

- a (11:7) The Greek of v. 7 is obscure, and the rendering is uncertain.
- b (11:27) Or "the guards who stand before us are not the tyrant's but those of the divine law"; the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 12

1 When this one too had died a blessed death, thrown into a cauldron, the seventh came forward, the youngest of all.[a] 2 The tyrant felt pity for him, although he had been terribly reviled by his brothers; 3 and seeing him already wrapped in chains, he had him brought nearer

and tried to win him over, saying, [4] "You see the end of your brothers' folly; for because of disobedience they have been racked to death. As for you, if you are not persuaded, you will be tortured miserably and will die before your time. [5] But if you are persuaded, you will be my Friend and will be a leader in the affairs of the kingdom." [6] And while urging these things, he sent for the boy's mother, so that, pitying her bereaved of so many sons, she might spur the survivor to become obedient and be saved. [7] But his mother urged him on in the Hebrew tongue,[b] as we will relate shortly afterward; and [8] he said, "Unbind me; let me speak to the king and to all his Friends with him." [9] And overjoyed at the boy's announcement, they quickly loosed him. [10] And running to the nearest of the frying pans, [11] he said, "Unholy tyrant, most ungodly of all the wicked, were you not ashamed, after receiving good things and the kingdom from God, to kill his servants and to rack those who practice piety? [12] For this, divine justice is storing you up for a more relentless and eternal fire and tortures, which throughout all eternity will not let you go. [13] Were you not ashamed, you most brutish creature, being a man yourself, to cut out the tongues of those who share your feelings and are made of the same elements, and to abuse and torture them in this way? [14] But they, dying nobly, fulfilled their piety toward God, whereas you will lament wretchedly for having killed without cause the contenders for virtue."[c] [15] Then, being himself about to die, he said, [16] "I do not desert the testimony[d] of my brothers. [17] I call upon the God of our fathers to become merciful to my race; [18] but on you he will bring retribution in the life you now live and after your death as well." [19] And having uttered this prayer, he flung himself down into the frying pans, and so gave up his life.[e]

Notes

- a (12:1) Swete prints "thrown into a cauldron" with a misplaced verse mark. The account of the seventh brother differs from 2 Macc 7:24–40.
- b (12:7) Greek "the Hebrew voice," probably meaning Aramaic or Hebrew; compare 16:15.
- c (12:14) Swete divides v. 14 into two verses (12:14–15), so that the verses after it are numbered one higher than here.
- d (12:16) Greek martyria, "witness" or "testimony."

• e (12:19) Literally “and so he gave it back.” Swete numbers this verse 12:20.

Chapter 13

1 If, then, the seven brothers despised sufferings even to death, it is
agreed on every side that devout reason is sole master of the passions.
2 For if they had been slaves to the passions and had eaten defiling
food, we would say that these had defeated them. 3 But in fact it was
not so; rather, by the reason that is praised before God they prevailed
over the passions. 4 And the supremacy of the mind cannot be over-
looked, for they mastered both passion and pains. 5 How then can one
fail to acknowledge the mastery of right reasoning over passion in
these men, who did not turn back before the agonies of fire?[a] 6 For
just as towers jutting out at harbors break the threatening waves and
provide a calm anchorage for those sailing in, 7 so the seven-towered
right reasoning of the young men, fortifying the harbor of piety, con-
quered the intemperance of the passions. 8 For having formed a sacred
chorus of piety, they encouraged one another, saying, 9 “Brothers, let
us die like brothers for the law; let us imitate the three young men in
Syria[b] who despised the furnace that was a match for them.[c] 10 Let us
not play the coward in the demonstration of piety.” 11 And one said,
“Courage, brother!” and another, “Bear up nobly!” 12 And another said,
“Remember where you came from, and by the hand of what father
Isaac endured to be slain as a sacrifice for piety’s sake.” 13 Every one
of them, and the whole band at once, gazing upon each other with
bright faces and great boldness, declared, “With all our heart let us
devote ourselves to the God who bestowed our souls, and let us lend
our bodies to the guarding of the law. 14 Let us not fear him who thinks
he kills; 15 for great is the struggle of the soul and the danger lying in
eternal torment for those who transgress the commandment of God.
16 Let us arm ourselves, then, with the mastery over the passions that
divine reason gives. 17 If we suffer like this, Abraham and Isaac and
Jacob will receive us, and all the fathers will praise us.” 18 And to each
one of their brothers as he was dragged away, those who remained
said, “Do not put us to shame, brother, nor prove false to those who
have died before us.”

19 You are not unaware of the bonds of affection of brotherhood, which the divine and all-wise providence has apportioned through the fathers to those begotten by them, and implanted through the mother's womb. 20 In it the brothers dwell for the same length of time, are formed over the same period, are nourished from the same blood, and are brought to completion through the same life; 21 they are delivered after equal periods of time, and drink milk from the same springs, from which their brother-loving souls are nourished together in their mother's embrace; 22 and they grow stronger still through being reared together, through daily companionship, through the rest of their education, and through our training in the law of God. 23 When the sympathy of brotherly love is so firmly established, the seven brothers held their harmony with one another with still deeper sympathy. 24 For being educated in the same law, practicing the same virtues, and brought up together in the just life, they loved one another all the more.[d] 25 For their common zeal for nobility strengthened their goodwill and harmony toward one another; 26 for together with piety it made their brotherly love more ardent. 27 But nevertheless, although nature, companionship, and virtuous habits were increasing the bonds of brotherhood for them, those who were left endured for piety's sake, seeing their brothers being abused and tortured to death.

Notes

- a (13:5) The Greek sentence is grammatically incomplete; the rendering gives the probable sense.
- b (13:9) That is, the three companions of Daniel (Dan 3), who were in Babylon; "Syria" is used loosely here for the eastern empire.
- c (13:9) Or "the furnace equal in strength to them"; the sense of the Greek is uncertain.
- d (13:24) Greek "they drew more to themselves"; the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 14

1 Beyond this, they even spurred each other on to the abuse, so as not merely to look down on their agonies but to rule over the passions that brotherly affection stirs. 2 O reasonings more kingly than a king and freer than the free! 3 O holy and well-tuned symphony of seven brothers on behalf of piety! 4 None of the seven youths turned coward

or shrank back before death, [5] but all of them, as though running the road to immortality, hastened on to death through tortures. [6] For just as hands and feet move in concert with the soul's guidance, so those holy youths, as though moved by the immortal soul of piety, were of one accord in going to death for its sake. [7] O all-holy sevenfold company of harmonious brothers! For just as the seven days of the world's creation are arranged around piety,[a] [8] so the youths, dancing in chorus around the number seven, encircled it, bringing to nothing the fear of tortures. [9] We now shudder as we hear of the affliction of those young men; but they, not only seeing it, and not only hearing the immediate word of threat, but actually suffering it, endured, and that in agonies by fire. [10] And what could be more painful than this? For the power of fire, being sharp and swift, quickly dissolved their bodies.

[11] And do not consider it a wonder that reason prevailed over those men in their tortures, since even a woman's mind despised still more varied agonies. [12] For she who mothered the seven youths sustained the racking inflicted on every one of her children. [13] Consider how complex is the affection of love for children, drawing everything toward the sympathy felt in the inward parts.[b] [14] Even irrational animals have a sympathy and affection for their offspring like that of human beings. [15] For among birds, the tame ones that nest on the roofs of houses defend their nestlings, [16] and those that make their nests and hatch their young on mountain peaks, in clefts of ravines, and in holes and tops of trees also ward off anyone who approaches; [17] and if they cannot keep him away, they fly in circles around their young, anguished with love, calling out in their own voice, and help their children in whatever way they can. [18] Yet what need is there to show from beasts without reason how tenderly creatures feel for their young, [19] when even bees, at the season of making honeycomb, ward off those who approach, and strike those who come near their hive with their sting as with a sword,[c] and defend it even to death? [20] But sympathy for her children did not move the mother of the young men, whose soul was like that of Abraham.[d]

Notes

- a (14:7) Or "move in a circle about piety"; the image of vv. 7–8 is obscure, apparently relating the seven brothers to the seven days of creation and the Sabbath.
- b (14:13) Greek splanchna, the inner organs regarded as the seat of feeling; here, the womb.
- c (14:19) Greek "as with iron."
- d (14:20) Compare Abraham's willingness to sacrifice Isaac (Gen 22), recalled in 16:20.

Chapter 15

1 O reasoning of sons, ruler absolute of passions! O godliness, dearer
to a mother than her own offspring![a] 2 Two things lay before the
mother: piety, and the temporary safety of her seven sons according
to the tyrant's promise. 3 She loved piety more, which saves to eternal
life in accordance with God. 4 O how can I describe in words the child-
loving passions of parents, which stamp a wonderful likeness of soul
and of form onto the small character of the child, especially since
mothers are more sympathetic toward their offspring than fathers? 5
For the weaker in soul mothers are, and the more children they bear,
the more they love their children. 6 Of all mothers, the mother of the
seven loved her children most, she who through seven pregnancies
had love for them planted in her, 7 and who, through her many birth
pangs for each of them, was compelled to feel sympathy for them; 8
yet because of the fear of God she disregarded the temporary safety
of her children. 9 More than this, the noble goodness of her sons and
their readiness to obey the law made her tenderness for them all
the greater. 10 For they were just, self-controlled, courageous, great-
souled, loving toward their brothers, and so loving toward their
mother that they obeyed her even to death in keeping the ordinances.
11 Nevertheless, though so many considerations connected with love
of children were drawing the mother toward sympathy, in the case
of none of them were the varied tortures able to turn her reason
aside. 12 Rather, the mother urged them, each child singly and all of
them together, on to death for the sake of piety. 13 O sacred nature
and affection of parents, love toward offspring, nurture, and uncon-
querable passions of mothers! 14 Seeing them racked and burned one
by one, the mother did not change her mind, because of piety. 15 She

saw her children's flesh melting in the fire, and the toes and fingers of their feet and hands quivering on the ground, and the flesh of their heads down to the chin laid out like masks. [16] O mother, tried now by bitterer pains than the birth pangs you suffered for them! [17] O woman, alone among women, who brought piety to birth whole and entire! [18] Your firstborn breathing his last did not turn you aside, nor the second looking piteously at you in his torments, nor the third expiring; [19] nor did you weep when you beheld the eyes of each one staring like a bull's[b] at the same abuse in the torments, and their nostrils signaling their death. [20] When you saw the flesh of children severed upon the flesh of children, hands cut off upon hands, heads flayed upon heads, and corpses falling upon corpses, and saw the place crowded with your children's bodies because of the tortures, you did not shed tears. [21] Not so do the melodies of the Sirens or the songs of swans[c] draw those who hear them to listen, as the voices of children calling to their mother in the midst of tortures. [22] How great and how many were the torments with which the mother was then tormented, while her sons were being tortured with wheels and with branding irons! [23] Yet reason grounded in piety, steeling her inmost being with manly courage amid the very passions, braced her to look past her love for her children, which was only for a time. [24] Although she saw the destruction of seven children and the intricate variety of the rackings, the noble mother, embracing them, let them go,[d] because of her faith toward God. [25] For as though seeing in her own soul, as in a council chamber, formidable counselors, nature and family and love of children and the racking of her children, [26] the mother, holding two votes, one bringing death and one bringing safety for her children, [27] did not choose the safety that would preserve seven sons for a short time, [28] rather, being a daughter of Abraham who revered God, she called to mind his steadfastness.

[29] O mother of the nation, champion of the law, defender of piety, and winner of the prize in the contest of the heart![e] [30] O more noble than males in fortitude, and more courageous than men in endurance! [31] For just as Noah's ark, bearing the world in the world-engulfing flood, withstood the mighty waves,[f] [32] so you, guardian of the law,

surrounded on every side by the flood of the passions and battered by the violent winds of your sons' tortures, nobly withstood the storms that came because of piety.

Notes

- a (15:1) Swete prints vv. 1–2 as one verse.
- b (15:19) Greek taurēdon, "with a bull-like glare."
- c (15:21) The Sirens of Greek legend lured sailors with their song; swans were said to sing beautifully before death.
- d (15:24) Greek "having embraced, she released"; the sense is uncertain.
- e (15:29) Greek splanchnon, "inward parts," the seat of feeling.
- f (15:31) Gen 6–8. "Noah" is associated with "rest" and "comfort" (Gen 5:29).

Chapter 16

1 If, then, a woman, an aged one at that, and the mother of seven children, endured seeing her children's tortures even to death, admittedly devout reason is absolute ruler over the passions. 2 I have demonstrated, then, that not only have men prevailed over the passions, but a woman too has despised the greatest tortures. 3 And the lions around Daniel[a] were not so fierce, nor was the furnace of Mishael,[b] blazing with most violent fire, so burning, as was her nature of love for children set aflame as she saw her seven sons being tortured. 4 But by the reason of piety the mother quenched passions so many and so great.

5 For consider this also: if the woman had been faint of soul, mother though she was, she would have lamented over them, and perhaps she would have spoken thus: 6 "Ah, wretched me, and thrice unhappy many times over! I have borne seven children and have become the mother of none. 7 O seven pregnancies all in vain, seven ten-month carryings to no profit,[c] nursings without fruit, and sufferings in suckling! 8 In vain, my sons, did I endure many birth pangs for you, and the more grievous anxieties of rearing you. 9 Alas for my children, some of you unmarried, and those who married without profit! I shall not see your children, nor shall I be called blessed as a grandmother. 10 Alas, I who had many and beautiful children am a widow, alone and full of lamenting! 11 Nor, when I die, will I have any of my sons to bury me."[d] But with no such lament did the holy and God-fearing mother

mourn any of them, [12] nor did she try to turn any of them away from dying, nor did she grieve as though they were perishing. [13] But as though she had a mind of adamant, and were bringing the number of her sons to birth again into immortality, she rather urged them on with supplication to death for the sake of piety. [14] O mother, soldier of God for the sake of piety, aged and a woman! By your endurance you conquered even a tyrant, and in deeds and words you proved more powerful than a man. [15] For when you were arrested along with your children, you stood watching Eleazar being tortured, and you said to your children in the Hebrew language,[e] [16] "My children, a noble contest it is into which you have been summoned to testify on the nation's behalf; strive in it with zeal for the law of our fathers. [17] For it would be shameful if this old man endured agonies for the sake of piety, while you, who are young, were terrified at the tortures. [18] Call to mind that it was by God's doing that you received your portion of the world and had the enjoyment of life, [19] and therefore you ought to endure every pain for God's sake. [20] For his sake also our father Abraham hastened to slaughter his son Isaac, the father of our nation; and Isaac, seeing his father's hand bearing a sword descending upon him, did not cower.[f] [21] Daniel too, the just one, was cast among lions, and Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael were flung as from a sling into a fiery furnace,[g] and for God's sake they held out. [22] You, then, who have the same faith toward God, must not be dismayed. [23] For it would be unreasonable for those who know piety not to stand firm against pains." [24] With these words the mother of seven, exhorting each one of her sons, persuaded them to die rather than transgress the commandment of God. [25] And they knew this also, that those who die for God's sake live to God, as do Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and all the patriarchs.

Notes

- a (16:3) Dan 6. "Daniel" means "God is my judge."
- b (16:3) Dan 3. "Mishael" probably means "who is what God is?"
- c (16:7) Pregnancy was commonly reckoned in antiquity as ten (lunar) months.
- d (16:11) Greek "I will have none of my sons burying me"; where the lament ends is a matter of punctuation.
- e (16:15) Compare 12:7. The language meant is probably Hebrew or Aramaic.

- f (16:20) Gen 22. The Greek is ambiguous as to whether it is Abraham or Isaac who "did not cower."
- g (16:21) Dan 3; 6. "Hananiah" means "the LORD has been gracious" and "Azariah" "the LORD has helped."

Chapter 17

1 Some of the guards also said that when she too was about to be arrested and executed, she hurled herself into the fire so that no one could touch her body.

2 O mother, who together with your seven sons broke down the violence of the tyrant, made void his evil designs, and displayed the nobility of faith! 3 For like a roof nobly set upon the pillars of your children, you bore without swaying the earthquake of the tortures. 4 Take courage, therefore, O mother of holy soul, holding firm the hope of your endurance toward God. 5 Not so majestic does the moon stand in heaven with the stars as you stand, honored before God, having lit the way to piety for your seven star-like sons; and you are fixed firmly in heaven with them. 6 For your childbearing was from Abraham the father.[a]

7 If it were permitted to us to paint, as an artist might, the piety of your story, would not those who looked on it shudder to see the mother of seven children enduring for piety's sake various tortures even to death? 8 Indeed it would be fitting to inscribe on their very tomb these words also, as a memorial to those of our nation: 9 "In this place are laid to rest an old priest, a woman far on in years, and seven sons, through the brute force of a tyrant bent on overthrowing the Hebrews' way of citizenship. 10 They also vindicated their nation, looking to God and enduring tortures even to death." 11 For truly the contest in which they engaged was divine. 12 For on that day virtue presided over the games, testing them by endurance. The prize was incorruption in long-lasting life. 13 Eleazar led off the contest; the mother of the seven sons competed alongside; and the brothers fought on. 14 The tyrant contended against them; the world and all human life looked on. 15 Reverence for God was victor and crowned her own athletes. 16 Who did not marvel at the athletes of the true legislation? Who were not astonished?

17 The tyrant himself and his whole council marveled at their
endurance, 18 because of which they now stand beside the divine
throne and live the blessed age. 19 For Moses declares, "And all the
holy ones are beneath your hands."[b] 20 So these, made holy on God's
account, have been honored, and not with this honor alone, but
also in this, that through them the foes gained no mastery over our
nation, 21 and the tyrant was punished, and the homeland purified, 22
for they became as though a life paid in exchange for the nation's
sin.[c] And through the blood of those devout ones and their atoning
death,[d] divine providence preserved Israel, which had previously
been afflicted.
23 For Antiochus the tyrant, beholding the manliness of their virtue
and how they held out amid the torments, held up their endurance
before his troops as a model, 24 and he had them noble and courageous
for infantry battle and for siege, and he ravaged and conquered all
his enemies.[e]

Notes

- a (17:6) Greek "from Abraham the child," probably meaning "from Abraham" with reference to the line descended from him; the phrase is obscure.
- b (17:19) Deut 33:3 (Greek).
- c (17:22) Greek antipsychon, "a life given in exchange."
- d (17:22) Greek hilastērion, "propitiatory" or "atoning"; the same word is used for the cover of the ark (the "mercy seat") in Exod 25:17.
- e (17:24) The Greek is abrupt; "them" apparently refers to his soldiers, who took the martyrs as their example.

Chapter 18

1 O Israelite children, offspring of the seed of Abraham,[a] obey this law
and be devout in every way,
2 knowing that devout reason is master of the passions, and not only
of pains from within but also of those from without.
3 Therefore those who gave over their bodies to pains for the sake of
piety were not only admired by human beings but were also deemed
worthy of a divine portion.

4 And because of them the nation obtained peace, and, renewing the observance of the law in the homeland, it took the enemies' strongholds by siege.
5 And the tyrant Antiochus has been punished on earth and is being chastised now that he is dead. For since he was in no way able to compel the people of Jerusalem to live like foreigners and to abandon the way of life of their ancestral nations,[b]
6 he then departed from Jerusalem and marched against the Persians.

¶The righteous mother of the seven sons also spoke these words to her children:

7 "I was a pure virgin, and I never left my father's house, but I kept watch over the rib that was built.[c]
8 No destroyer in the desert or seducer in the field corrupted me,[d] nor did the destroyer, the serpent of deceit, defile the purity of my virginity.[e] I remained with my husband through the time of my prime.
9 When these sons had grown to maturity, their father died. Happy was he! For having lived a life blessed with good children, he did not suffer the grief of the time of childlessness.
10 He, while yet among us, instructed you in the law and the prophets.
11 He read to us of Abel, slain by Cain,[f] of Isaac, offered as a burnt offering,[g] and of Joseph in prison.[h]
12 He spoke to us of Phinehas the zealot,[i] and to you he gave instruction concerning Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael amid the fire.
13 He glorified Daniel in the den of lions and called him blessed.
14 He reminded you of the scripture of Isaiah[j] that says, 'Even if you pass through fire, the flame shall not burn you.'[k]
15 He sang to us David the hymn writer,[l] who says, 'Many are the afflictions of the righteous.'[m]
16 He recited to us the proverbs of Solomon,[n] who says, 'He is a tree of life to all who do his will.'[o]
17 He confirmed Ezekiel,[p] who says, 'Shall these dry bones live?'[q]
18 For he did not forget the song that Moses taught, which teaches, 'I will kill, and I will make alive.'[r]
19 This is your life and the length of your days."[s]

20 O bitter was that day, and yet not bitter, when the bitter tyrant of
the Greeks lit a fire under his savage cauldrons,[t] and in his seething
fury hauled the seven sons of Abraham's daughter to the catapult
and then back again to his tortures, 21 pierced the pupils of their eyes,
cut out their tongues, and put them to death with various tortures. 22
For these things divine justice pursued and will pursue the accursed
wretch. 23 But the sons of Abraham, with their mother who won the
prize, are gathered together into the place of their fathers, having
received pure and immortal souls from God, 24 to whom be the glory
forever and ever. Amen.

Notes

- a (18:1) "Abraham" is explained in Gen 17:5 as "father of a multitude."
- b (18:5) Greek "ancestral nations"; the sense is probably "ancestral customs."
- c (18:7) Gen 2:22, where the woman is "built" from the man's rib; that is, she guarded her own body.
- d (18:8) Compare Deut 22:25–27.
- e (18:8) Gen 3:1–13.
- f (18:11) Gen 4:8. "Abel" means "breath" or "vapor"; "Cain" is linked by sound with "I have acquired" (Gen 4:1).
- g (18:11) Gen 22.
- h (18:11) Gen 39:20–23.
- i (18:12) Num 25:7–13. "Phinehas" is probably of Egyptian origin, perhaps meaning "the Nubian"; uncertain.
- j (18:14) "Isaiah" means "the LORD is salvation."
- k (18:14) Isa 43:2.
- l (18:15) "David" is often explained as "beloved"; uncertain.
- m (18:15) Ps 34:19 (Ps 33:20 in the Greek).
- n (18:16) "Solomon" is related to the Hebrew word for "peace."
- o (18:16) Prov 3:18. The Greek "his will" is unclear; Proverbs speaks of wisdom.
- p (18:17) "Ezekiel" means "God strengthens."
- q (18:17) Ezek 37:3.
- r (18:18) Deut 32:39. "Moses" is explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out."
- s (18:19) Deut 30:20.
- t (18:20) The Greek here is obscure; literally "having kindled fire with cruel cauldrons."

1 Esdras

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

1 And Josiah[a] kept the Passover in Jerusalem to his Lord,[b] and they
sacrificed the Passover on the fourteenth day of the first month
(in March–April),[c] 2 having set the priests according to their daily
courses, arrayed in their vestments, in the temple of the Lord. 3 And he
told the Levites, the temple servants of Israel, to sanctify themselves
to the Lord for the placing of the holy ark of the Lord in the house
that King Solomon the son of David had built: 4 "You shall not carry it
upon your shoulders any longer. Now therefore serve the Lord your
God, and minister to his nation Israel, and prepare yourselves by your
families and your tribes, according to the writing of David king of
Israel and according to the magnificence of Solomon his son; 5 and
standing in the holy place according to the divisions of the families
of you Levites, who serve before your brothers the sons of Israel, 6 in
order, sacrifice the Passover, and make ready the sacrifices for your
brothers, and keep the Passover according to the commandment of
the Lord which was given to Moses."
7 And Josiah gave to the people who were present thirty thousand
lambs and kids, and three thousand calves; these were given out of
the king's possessions, as he had promised, to the people and to the
priests and Levites. 8 Hilkiah, Zechariah and Esyelus,[d] the overseers
of the temple, gave the priests two thousand six hundred sheep and
three hundred calves for the Passover. 9 And Jeconiah and Shemaiah
and Nathanael his brother, and Hashabiah and Ochielus and Joram,
captains over thousands, gave to the Levites for the Passover a thou-
sand sheep[e] and seven hundred calves.
10 And when these things had been done, the priests and the Levites
stood in fair order, having the unleavened bread, according to the
tribes and according to the divisions of the fathers' houses, before

the people, to make offering to the Lord as it is written in the book of Moses; and so they did in the morning. 11 And they roasted the Passover with fire as was fitting, and boiled the sacrifices in the brass pots and caldrons with a sweet savor, and carried them to all the people. 12 And after this they made ready for themselves and for the priests their brothers, the sons of Aaron; 13 for the priests were offering the fat until late at night; and the Levites made ready for themselves and for the priests their brothers, the sons of Aaron. 14 And the holy singers, the sons of Asaph, were in their order according to what had been ordained by David, and Asaph and Zechariah and Eddinus,[f] who were of the king's appointing; 15 and the gatekeepers were at every gate; none needed to depart from his own course, for their brothers the Levites made ready for them.

16 So the things belonging to the sacrifice of the Lord were accomplished on that day: the Passover was kept, and the sacrifices were offered upon the altar of the Lord, according to the command of King Josiah. 17 The Israelites who were there at that time observed the Passover and the festival of unleavened bread for seven days. 18 And there had not been kept such a Passover in Israel from the time of the prophet Samuel; 19 and none of the kings of Israel kept such a Passover as Josiah kept, with the priests and the Levites and the Jews and all Israel who were found dwelling in Jerusalem. 20 This Passover was held in the eighteenth year that Josiah reigned. 21 And the works of Josiah were upright before his Lord, with a heart full of godliness. 22 The events of his time have been recorded in former times, concerning those who sinned and acted ungodly toward the Lord beyond every nation and kingdom, and how they grieved him;[g] and the words of the Lord rose up against Israel.

23 And after all these acts of Josiah, it came to pass that Pharaoh king of Egypt came to make war at Carchemish[h] on the Euphrates, and Josiah went out against him. 24 And the king of Egypt sent to him, saying, "What have I to do with you, O king of Judea? 25 I have not been sent against you by the Lord God, for my war is upon the Euphrates. And now the Lord is with me; yes, the Lord is with me, urging me on. Withdraw, and do not oppose the Lord." 26 But Josiah

did not turn his chariot back from him, but undertook to fight him, not heeding the words of Jeremiah[i] the prophet from the mouth of the Lord. 27 Necho met him in battle on the plain of Megiddo,[j] and his commanders marched down against King Josiah. 28 And the king said to his servants, "Carry me out of the fight, for I am grievously weak." And at once his servants bore him away out of the battle line. 29 And he got up into his second chariot, and when he had been brought back to Jerusalem he departed this life, and was buried in the tomb of his fathers. 30 All Judea mourned for Josiah. The prophet Jeremiah sang a lament for him, and the leading men, together with the women, have mourned him to this day; it was made a permanent custom throughout the nation of Israel. 31 These things are written in the book of the histories of the kings of Judea, and every one of the deeds that Josiah did, and his glory, and his understanding in the law of the Lord; and the things that he had done before, and the things now told, are recorded in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah.
32 And the men of the nation took Jeconiah[k] the son of Josiah and made him king in the place of Josiah his father, when he was twenty-three years old. 33 And he reigned in Israel[l] and Jerusalem three months. And the king of Egypt deposed him from reigning in Jerusalem, 34 and laid a fine upon the nation of about 7,500 pounds of silver and about 75 pounds of gold.[m] 35 And the king of Egypt made Jehoiakim[n] his brother king of Judea and Jerusalem. 36 And Jehoiakim bound the nobles; but Zarius[o] his brother he seized and brought up out of Egypt.
37 Jehoiakim was twenty-five years old when he began to reign over Judea and Jerusalem, and he did what was evil before the Lord. 38 And against him came up Nebuchadnezzar[p] king of Babylon, and bound him with a chain of bronze and carried him away to Babylon. 39 And Nebuchadnezzar took some of the holy vessels of the Lord and carried them away and set them up in his own temple in Babylon. 40 But the things that are reported about him, and about his uncleanness and impiety, are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings.
41 And Jehoiakim[q] his son reigned in his place; for when he was made king he was eight years old.[r] 42 And he reigned three months and ten days in Jerusalem, and did what was evil before the Lord. 43

And after a year Nebuchadnezzar sent and removed him to Babylon, together with the holy vessels of the Lord, 44 and made Zedekiah[s] king of Judea and Jerusalem, when Zedekiah was twenty-one years old; and he reigned eleven years. 45 And he wrought evil before the Lord, and gave no regard to the words spoken by the prophet Jeremiah out of the Lord's mouth. 46 And though he had been made to swear by the name of the Lord to King Nebuchadnezzar, he broke his oath and rebelled; and he hardened his neck and his heart and transgressed the ordinances of the Lord, the God of Israel. 47 And the leaders of the people and of the priests also did many ungodly and lawless deeds, more than all the uncleannesses of all the nations, and defiled the temple of the Lord which was sanctified in Jerusalem. 48 And the God of their fathers sent by his messenger to call them back, because he was sparing them and his dwelling place. 49 But they mocked his messengers, and on the day the Lord spoke, they were scoffing at his prophets, until he, being angry with his nation because of their ungodly deeds, commanded the kings of the Chaldeans[t] to come up against them. 50 These put their youths to the sword round about the holy temple, and spared neither youth nor maiden, neither aged man nor child,[u] but he gave them all over into their hands. 51 And they took all the holy vessels of the Lord, great and small, and the chests[v] of the Lord and the king's treasuries, and carried them away to Babylon. 52 And they set fire to the house of the Lord, and broke down the walls of Jerusalem, and burned its towers with fire, 53 and utterly made all its glorious things useless. And those who were left he carried away with the sword to Babylon; 54 and they were servants to him and to his sons until the Persians reigned, to fulfill the word of the Lord by the mouth of Jeremiah: 55 "Until the land has enjoyed its sabbaths, all the time of its desolation it shall keep sabbath, to fulfill seventy years."[w]

Notes

- a (1:1) Josiah means "Yahweh supports" or "Yahweh heals" (uncertain). He reigned over Judah about 640–609 BC. 1 Esdras 1:1–55 parallels 2 Chronicles 35:1–36:21 (compare 2 Kings 23:21–25:21).
- b (1:1) Greek Kyrios, "Lord," the word the Septuagint uses for the divine name YHWH; in 2 Chronicles 35:1 the Hebrew has "Yahweh." "Lord" in this book renders Kyrios throughout.

- c (1:1) Greek "on the fourteenth day of the first month," that is, Nisan, on the spring-start calendar (Exodus 12:6).
- d (1:8) Hebrew Jehiel in 2 Chronicles 35:8. Hilkiah means "Yahweh is my portion"; he is the high priest of 2 Kings 22.
- e (1:9) Swete's text reads "a thousand"; 2 Chronicles 35:9 and other Greek copies (followed by the King James Version) read "five thousand."
- f (1:14) In 2 Chronicles 35:15 the singers are Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun; the Greek names here (Zechariah and Eddinus) may be corruptions of these. Asaph means "he gathers."
- g (1:22) Greek "and the things which grieved him"; the Greek of this verse, which has no parallel in Chronicles, is difficult.
- h (1:23) Carchemish, a fortress city on the upper Euphrates, where Pharaoh Neco fought in 609 and 605 BC (Jeremiah 46:2). The Greek has Karkamys. Pharaoh is Neco II (2 Chronicles 35:20).
- i (1:26) Jeremiah means "Yahweh exalts" or "Yahweh establishes" (uncertain). In 2 Chronicles 35:22 the words come "from the mouth of God" through Neco himself; 1 Esdras attributes them to Jeremiah.
- j (1:27) Greek Metaaddous, a corrupted form of Megiddo (2 Chronicles 35:22), the city guarding the pass into the plain of Jezreel.
- k (1:32) In 2 Chronicles 36:1 and 2 Kings 23:30 this son is Jehoahaz (also called Shallum, Jeremiah 22:11); the Greek here has Iechonias.
- l (1:33) Greek "in Israel," where 2 Chronicles 36:2 has "in Jerusalem" only.
- m (1:34) Greek "a hundred talents of silver and one talent of gold." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms), so about 3,400 kilograms of silver and 34 kilograms of gold; standards varied.
- n (1:35) Greek Iōakeim. Jehoiakim means "Yahweh raises up"; he reigned about 609–598 BC (2 Chronicles 36:4–8).
- o (1:36) Greek Zarion (some copies Zarakēs). In 2 Chronicles 36:4 it is Jehoahaz whom Neco takes to Egypt; the Greek here has garbled the account.
- p (1:38) Nebuchadnezzar (Greek Nabouchodonosor) means "O Nabu, protect the heir" (Akkadian Nabû-kudurri-uṣur). He reigned in Babylon 605–562 BC.
- q (1:41) Greek Iōakeim again, here for the son of Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin (also called Jeconiah), who reigned in 598–597 BC (2 Chronicles 36:9).
- r (1:41) So also 2 Chronicles 36:9 (Hebrew); 2 Kings 24:8 has "eighteen years old."
- s (1:44) Zedekiah means "Yahweh is righteousness"; he reigned 597–586 BC.
- t (1:49) The Chaldeans were the dominant people of the Neo-Babylonian kingdom.
- u (1:50) Greek neōteros, "younger one"; 2 Chronicles 36:17 has "the aged and the infirm," and the Greek copies vary.
- v (1:51) Greek kibōtous, "chests, arks," probably the treasure chests of the temple (2 Chronicles 36:18 has "the treasures of the house of Yahweh").

- w (1:55) Compare Leviticus 26:34–35 and Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10. Here 1 Esdras ends its parallel to Chronicles; 2:1–15 follows Ezra 1 (compare 2 Chronicles 36:22–23).

Chapter 2

1 In the first year that Cyrus[a] was king of the Persians, so that the
word of the Lord spoken through Jeremiah would be fulfilled, 2 the
Lord moved the heart of Cyrus, king of the Persians, and he sent out a
proclamation, spoken and written, across his whole kingdom: 3 "This
is what Cyrus, king of the Persians, says: The Lord Most High, the
Lord of Israel, has appointed me king over the whole world, 4 and
has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem in Judea. 5 So if
any of you belong to his people, may his Lord be with him, and let
him go to Jerusalem in Judea and rebuild the house of the Lord of
Israel, the Lord who lives in Jerusalem. 6 As many, then, as dwell in
the various places, let those who are in his place help him with gold
and with silver, with gifts, with horses and cattle, besides the other
things added as freewill offerings[b] for the temple of the Lord which
is in Jerusalem."
7 Then the heads of the families of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin
got ready,[c] along with the priests, the Levites, and everyone whose
spirit the Lord had moved to go and build a house for the Lord
in Jerusalem; 8 and their neighbors supported them in every way,
giving silver and gold, horses and livestock, and a very large number
of freewill offerings from many whose hearts had been moved. 9
King Cyrus also brought out the holy vessels of the Lord, which
Nebuchadnezzar had carried away from Jerusalem and set up in his
idol temple. 10 And when Cyrus king of the Persians had brought them
out, he delivered them to Mithridates[d] his treasurer, 11 and by him
they were delivered to Sanabassar,[e] the governor of Judea. 12 Their
number was: thirty gold bowls, two thousand four hundred ten silver
bowls,[f] twenty-nine silver censers, a thousand gold cups for drink
offerings, a thousand silver cups for drink offerings, and a thousand
other vessels. 13 All the vessels, gold and silver, that were brought were
five thousand four hundred and sixty-nine; 14 and they were brought

up by Sanabassar together with the returning exiles from Babylon to Jerusalem.

15 But in the time of Artaxerxes[g] king of the Persians, Belemus and Mithridates and Tabellius and Rathumus and Beeltethmus,[h] and Samellius the scribe, and the rest who were associated with them, dwelling in Samaria and the other places, wrote to him against those who were dwelling in Judea and Jerusalem the following letter: 16 "To King Artaxerxes, our lord, from your servants Rathumus the recorder and Samellius the scribe, and the rest of their council, and those in Coele-Syria and Phoenicia.[i] 17 May our lord the king know that the Jews who traveled from you to us have settled in Jerusalem and are now rebuilding that rebellious and wicked city, restoring its markets and walls and laying the foundations of a temple. 18 If this city is rebuilt and its walls completed, they will not only refuse to pay tribute but will even rise up against kings. Since the work on the temple is under way, we think it right not to ignore such a matter, but to bring it to our lord the king, so that, if you approve, a search can be made in the records of your ancestors. 19 And you will find in the records what is written about these things, and you will learn that that city was rebellious, troubling both kings and cities, and that the Jews were rebels and had been raising sieges in it from of old; for which cause also this city was laid waste. 20 Now therefore we make known to you, our lord the king, that if this city is built and its walls are set up again, you will no longer have any access to Coele-Syria and Phoenicia."

21 Then the king wrote back to Rathumus the recorder, and Beeltethmus, and Samellius the scribe, and the rest who were associated with them and dwelling in Samaria and Syria and Phoenicia, as follows: 22 "I have read the letter which you have sent to me. Therefore I commanded that search be made, and it was found that that city from of old has set itself against kings, 23 and that the men in it were given to rebellions and wars, and that mighty and stern kings ruled in Jerusalem and exacted tribute from Coele-Syria and Phoenicia. 24 Now therefore I have commanded that those men be hindered from building the city, and that heed be taken that nothing more be done

contrary to this, and that such wickedness proceed no further to the annoyance of kings."
25 Then, when the things written by King Artaxerxes had been read, Rathumus and Samellius the scribe and those associated with them went in haste to Jerusalem with cavalry and a crowd in battle array, and began to hinder the builders. And the building of the temple in Jerusalem ceased until the second year of the reign of Darius[j] king of the Persians.

Notes

- a (2:1) Cyrus (Greek Kyros; Persian Kūruš, meaning uncertain) founded the Persian empire and took Babylon in 539 BC. 2:1–14 parallels Ezra 1:1–11 and 2 Chronicles 36:22–23.
- b (2:6) Greek kat' euchas, "according to vows," that is, offerings made in fulfillment of vows; compare Ezra 1:4.
- c (2:7) Greek "having been established," a difficult reading; compare Ezra 1:5, "rose up." Judah means "praised"; Benjamin means "son of the right hand."
- d (2:10) Hebrew Mithredath (Ezra 1:8), a Persian name meaning "given by Mithra."
- e (2:11) Hebrew Sheshbazzar (Ezra 1:8), a Babylonian name of uncertain meaning; the Greek copies spell it in several ways (Sanabassaros, Samanassaros).
- f (2:12) Greek "silver bowls, 2,410" (written with Greek numerals); Ezra 1:10 has "410 silver bowls of a second sort." The total in verse 13 (5,469) agrees with neither list exactly; Ezra 1:11 gives 5,400.
- g (2:15) Artaxerxes I, king of Persia 465–424 BC. 2:15–25 parallels Ezra 4:7–24, but 1 Esdras places this correspondence before the reign of Darius (chs. 3–7), out of chronological order.
- h (2:15) In Ezra 4:7–9 the writers are Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, Rehum the commander (Aramaic be'el-te'em, "master of decree"), and Shimshai the scribe. The Greek has turned Rehum's title into a further name, Beeltethmus.
- i (2:16) Coele-Syria, "Hollow Syria," the Greek name for the region between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon ranges, here used, as often in Hellenistic Greek, for the Persian province "Beyond the River" west of the Euphrates. Phoenicia is the coastland of Tyre and Sidon.
- j (2:25) Darius I, king of Persia 522–486 BC; his second year is 520 BC (Ezra 4:24; Haggai 1:1). Darius means "holding firm the good."

Chapter 3

1 Now King Darius made a great feast for all who were under him, and for all who were born in his house, and for all the nobles of Media and of Persia, 2 and for all the satraps and generals and governors[a] who

were under him, from India to Ethiopia,[b] in the hundred and twenty-
seven satrapies. 3 They ate and drank until they were full, and then
left; King Darius went to his bedroom and slept, and later woke up.[c]
4 Then the three young men of the bodyguard, who kept watch over
the king's person, said one to another, 5 "Let each of us name one
thing that is strongest; and he whose saying seems wiser than the
others', to him shall Darius the king give great gifts and great honors
of victory: 6 to be clothed in purple, and to drink from gold cups, and
to sleep on a gold bed, and a chariot with a gold bridle, and a turban of
fine linen, and a chain about his neck; 7 and he shall sit next to Darius
because of his wisdom, and shall be called Darius's kinsman."[d] 8 And
then they each wrote his own saying, and sealed it, and put it under
the pillow of Darius the king, and said, 9 "When the king wakes up,
they will hand him the document; and whichever of us the king and
the three nobles of Persia judge to have given the wisest statement
will be awarded the victory, as it is written." 10 The first wrote, "Wine
is strongest." 11 The second wrote, "The king is strongest." 12 The third
wrote, "Women are strongest, but above all things truth is victor."[e]
13 And when the king awoke, they took the writing and gave it to him,
and he read it. 14 And he sent and called all the nobles of Persia and of
Media, and the satraps and generals and governors and chief officers,
and sat down in the council chamber, and the writing was read before
them. 15 And he said, "Call the young men, and they shall explain their
own sayings." So they were called, and came in. 16 And they said to
them, "Declare to us your meaning concerning the things written."
Then the first, who had spoken of the strength of wine, began, and
said thus: 17 "Sirs, how strong wine is! It leads astray the mind of all
men who drink it. 18 It makes the mind of the king and of the orphan
to be all one, of the slave and of the free, of the poor and of the rich.
19 It turns every thought to feasting and merriment, so that a man
remembers no sorrow nor any debt. 20 It makes every heart rich, so
that a man remembers neither king nor satrap, and it makes all men
talk in large sums.[f] 21 And when they drink they forget to show love to
friends and brothers, and before long they draw their swords; 22 and
when they wake from their wine, they do not remember what they

have done. 23 Sirs, is not wine the strongest, since it compels men to do these things?" And when he had said this, he was silent.

Notes

- a (3:2) Greek toparchais, "district rulers." 3:1–5:6, the contest of Darius's three bodyguards (the "Story of the Three Youths" or "Three Guardsmen"), has no parallel in Ezra, Nehemiah, or any other book of the Hebrew Bible; it is the one large section of 1 Esdras found nowhere else in Scripture. Many scholars think it was an originally independent tale, perhaps first told of an anonymous youth, which was then attached to Zerubbabel (4:13) and used to explain how the rebuilding of the temple was renewed under Darius.
- b (3:2) Greek Aithiopia, the land south of Egypt (Hebrew Cush). Compare Esther 1:1, which also gives 127 provinces.
- c (3:3) Greek "and became wakeful." Some interpreters take it to mean that he slept only a little.
- d (3:7) Greek syngenēs, "kinsman," an honorary title in the Persian and Hellenistic courts for the king's highest favorites.
- e (3:12) Some Greek copies, as reported, lack "but above all things truth is victor," which anticipates 4:33–41.
- f (3:20) Greek dia talantōn, "by talents," that is, it makes people talk as though they had talents of money (a talent was about 75 pounds of silver).

Chapter 4

1 Then the second, who had spoken of the strength of the king, began to speak: 2 "Sirs, do not men excel in strength, who bear rule over sea and land and all things in them? 3 Yet the king is mightier, for he is lord over them and has dominion over them, and whatever he bids them they do. 4 If he bids them make war one against another, they do it; if he sends them forth against the enemies, they march, and break down mountains and walls and towers. 5 They kill and are killed, yet never disobey the king's order; if they win, they bring everything to the king: all the plunder they take, and all else besides. 6 And those who are not soldiers and do not go to war, but till the ground, when they have sown, they reap again and bring it to the king; and they compel one another to bring the tribute to the king. 7 And yet he is only one man: if he says to kill, they kill; if he says to spare, they spare; 8 if he says to strike, they strike; if he says to lay waste, they lay waste; if he says to build, they build; 9 if he says to cut down, they cut down; if he says to plant, they plant. 10 And all his people and his

armies obey him. Moreover he reclines at table, eats and drinks, and
sleeps; 11 but they keep watch round about him, and none of them
may go away and do his own work, nor do they disobey him. 12 Sirs,
how can the king not be strongest, when he is obeyed in this way?"
And he was silent.
13 Then the third, who had spoken of women and of truth (this was
Zerubbabel[a]), began to speak: 14 "Sirs, is the king not great, and are
men not many, and is wine not mighty? Who then has dominion over
them, or who rules them? Is it not women? 15 It was women who bore
the king and all the people who rule over sea and land. 16 Of them men
were born; and women nourished up those who planted the vine-
yards from which the wine comes. 17 Women make men's garments;
they bring men glory;[b] and men cannot exist without women. 18 If
men gather gold and silver and every lovely thing, and then see one
woman who is fair in looks and beauty, 19 they let all those things
go and gape at her, and with mouths open they stare at her, and all
choose her rather than gold or silver or any lovely thing. 20 A man
leaves behind the father who brought him up, and his homeland, and
is joined to his wife. 21 With his wife he ends his days,[c] and remembers
neither father nor mother nor country. 22 And by this you must know
that women have dominion over you: do you not labor and travail,
and give and bring all to women? 23 A man takes his sword and goes
out to make raids and to rob and steal, and to sail upon the sea and
upon rivers; 24 he faces the lion and walks in darkness; and when he
has stolen and plundered and robbed, he brings it to his beloved. 25
A man loves his own wife more than father or mother. 26 Yes, many
have run mad for women's sake, and many have been made bondmen
for them. 27 Many have perished, and stumbled, and sinned because
of women. 28 And now do you not believe me? Is not the king great
in his power? Do not all lands fear to touch him? 29 Yet I have seen
him with Apame,[d] the king's concubine and daughter of the famous
Bartacus, seated at the king's right hand, 30 taking the crown from the
king's head and putting it on her own, and slapping the king with
her left hand. 31 And at this the king would gaze at her with his mouth
open. If she smiles at him, he laughs; and if she is cross with him, he

coaxes her, that she may be reconciled to him. 32 Sirs, how can women
not be strong, since they do such things?"
33 Then the king and the great men looked one upon another; so he
began to speak of truth: 34 "Sirs, are women not strong? Great is the
earth, high is the heaven, swift is the sun in his course, for he wheels
around the compass of the heaven and runs again to his own place in
one day. 35 Is not he great who does these things? But truth is great,
and stronger than all things. 36 All the earth calls upon truth, and the
heaven blesses her; all works shake and tremble at her,[e] and with her
is no unrighteous thing. 37 Wine is unrighteous, the king is unright-
eous, women are unrighteous, all the sons of men are unrighteous,
and all their works are unrighteous, all such things as these; there
is no truth in them, and in their unrighteousness they shall perish. 38
But truth endures and is strong for ever; she lives and conquers for
evermore. 39 With her there is no respect of persons or favoritism, but
she does what is just rather than anything unjust or wicked; and all
approve her works. 40 In her judgment there is nothing unrighteous.
To her belong the strength and the kingship and the authority and
the majesty of all ages. Blessed be the God of truth!" 41 And he ceased
speaking; and all the people then shouted, and said, "Great is truth,
and strongest of all!"[f]
42 Then the king said to him, "Ask what you wish, even more than is
written, and we will give it to you, inasmuch as you have been found
the wisest; and you shall sit next to me and be called my kinsman." 43
Then he said to the king, "Remember the vow which you vowed, to
build Jerusalem, on the day you received your kingdom, 44 and to send
back all the vessels that were taken out of Jerusalem, which Cyrus set
apart when he vowed to destroy Babylon, and vowed to send them
back there.[g] 45 You also vowed to build the temple that the Edomites[h]
burned when the Chaldeans devastated Judea. 46 And now, my lord
the king, this is what I ask of you, and it is a worthy act for someone
of your greatness: I urge you to keep the vow that you made with
your own mouth to the King of heaven."
47 Then Darius the king rose and kissed him, and wrote letters for
him to all the stewards and governors and generals and satraps, that

they should escort him and all who were going up with him to build Jerusalem. 48 He also wrote letters to all the governors in Coele-Syria and Phoenicia and Lebanon, telling them to bring cedar wood from Lebanon to Jerusalem and to help him rebuild the city. 49 Also he wrote on behalf of all the Jews that went up out of his realm into Judea, concerning their freedom, that no officer or satrap or governor or steward should forcibly enter their doors,[i] 50 and that all the country which they would hold should be theirs free of tribute, and that the Chaldeans[j] should give up the villages of the Jews which they held; 51 and that about 1,500 pounds of silver[k] should be given yearly toward the building of the temple until it was built, 52 and another 750 pounds or so yearly for burnt offerings to be offered on the altar every day, as they had a commandment to offer seventeen;[l] 53 And to all that went up from Babylonia to build the city he granted freedom, both to them and to their children, and to all the priests that went up. 54 He wrote also concerning their support, and the priestly vestments in which they minister.[m] 55 And for the Levites he wrote that their support should be given them until the day when the house should be finished and Jerusalem built. 56 And for all who guarded the city he wrote that allotments of land and wages should be given them. 57 And he sent back all the vessels which Cyrus had set apart from Babylon; and all that Cyrus had said should be done, he also commanded to be done and sent to Jerusalem.

58 When the young man left, he looked up toward heaven in the direction of Jerusalem and blessed the King of heaven, saying, 59 "From you comes victory, and from you comes wisdom, and yours is the glory, and I am your servant. 60 Blessed are you, who have given me wisdom; and to you I give thanks, O Master of our fathers." 61 And he took the letters, and went out to Babylon, and told it to all his brothers. 62 And they blessed the God of their fathers, because he had given them release and liberty 63 to go up and build Jerusalem and the temple which is called by his name; and they feasted with music and gladness seven days.

Notes

- a (4:13) Zerubbabel (Greek Zorobabel) means "seed of Babylon." He was the grandson of King Jehoiachin (1 Chronicles 3:17–19) and governor of Judah under Darius (Haggai 1:1). The identification here of the third guardsman with Zerubbabel links the story to the return in 5:1–6.
- b (4:17) Some Greek copies, as reported, read "they make men's garments and bring men glory," referring the clauses to women; others connect the glory with the garments.
- c (4:21) Greek aphiēsi tēn psychēn, "lets go his life," perhaps meaning "he gives up his life" or "he spends his life."
- d (4:29) Apame, daughter of Bartacus, is otherwise unknown as a concubine of Darius. The names are Persian; an Apame was the wife of Seleucus I, and the name was common at Hellenistic courts.
- e (4:36) Greek "all the works," that is, all created things; the Greek is literally "all works quake and tremble."
- f (4:41) Greek Megalē hē alētheia kai hyperischyei, "Great is truth, and it prevails over all." In the Latin Vulgate (3 Esdras 4:41) the saying became the proverb Magna est veritas et praevalet, "Truth is great and prevails."
- g (4:44) The Greek of verses 43–44 is awkward; the sense is that Cyrus, when he vowed to destroy Babylon, set apart the vessels and vowed to send them back (compare 2:9–11).
- h (4:45) Swete's text reads "the Jews," evidently a corruption; other Greek witnesses, as reported, read "the Idumeans," that is, the Edomites, who were remembered as joining in the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC (Psalm 137:7; Obadiah 11–14).
- i (4:49) Literally "not come upon their doors," that is, not intrude into their homes to requisition or tax them.
- j (4:50) Swete's text has "Chaldeans" here; other Greek witnesses, as reported, read "Idumeans" (Edomites), as in verse 45.
- k (4:51) Greek "twenty talents." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kilograms); the metal is not stated, but silver is probably meant, so about 680 kilograms. Verse 52 likewise has "ten other talents" (about 750 pounds or 340 kilograms).
- l (4:52) Swete's text reads "to offer seventeen"; the meaning is obscure, and the number may refer to a daily quota of sacrifices.
- m (4:54) Some Greek copies, as reported, read "and the priestly vestments, in which they shall minister," that is, Darius also provided the vestments.

Chapter 5

1 After this the chiefs of the fathers' houses were chosen to go up according to their tribes, with their wives and sons and daughters, and their menservants and maidservants, and their cattle. 2 And Darius sent with them a thousand horsemen to bring them back to Jerusalem

in safety, with music, drums, and flutes; [3] and all their brothers were making merry. And he made them go up together with them.
[4] These are the names of the men who went up, listed by their ancestral families in their tribes and by their divisions. [5] The priests, the sons of Phinehas,[a] the sons of Aaron: Jeshua the son of Jozadak, son of Saraeus; and Joakim the son of Zerubbabel,[b] son of Salathiel, of the house of David, of the lineage of Phares, of the tribe of Judah, [6] who spoke wise words before Darius king of the Persians in the second year of his reign, in the month Nisan, the first month (March–April).[c] [7] And these are they of Judea who came up from the captivity of their sojourning, whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had carried away to Babylon, [8] and who returned to Jerusalem and to the rest of Judea, each to his own city, who came with Zerubbabel and Jeshua, Nehemiah, Zaraeus, Resaeus, Enenius, Mardochaeus, Beelsarus, Aspharasus, Borolius, Roimus, and Baana, their leaders.[d] [9] The number of those of the nation, and their leaders: the sons of Phoros, two thousand one hundred and seventy-two;[e] [10] the sons of Ares, seven hundred and fifty-six; [11] the sons of Phaathmoab, of the sons of Jeshua and Joab, two thousand eight hundred and two;[f] [12] the sons of Olamus, two;[g] the sons of Zatton, nine hundred and seventy; the sons of Chorbe, seven hundred and five; the sons of Bani, six hundred and forty-eight; [13] the sons of Bebai, six hundred and thirty-three; the sons of Argai,[h] one thousand three hundred and twenty-two; [14] the sons of Adonikam, thirty-seven;[i] the sons of Bosai, two thousand six hundred and six; the sons of Adilius, four hundred and fifty-four; [15] the sons of Azer of Hezekiah,[j] the sons of Kilan and Azetas, sixty-seven; the sons of Azarus, four hundred and thirty-two; [16] the sons of Annis, a hundred and one; the sons of Arom; the sons of Bassai, three hundred and twenty-three; the sons of Arsiphurith,[k] [17] the sons of Baeterus, three thousand and five; the sons of Rhagethlomon,[l] a hundred and twenty-three; [18] those from Netebas, fifty-five; those from Enatus, a hundred and fifty-eight; those from Baetasmon, Zammoth;[m] [19] those from Kartathiarius,[n] twenty-five; those from Piras and Beroth, seven hundred; [20] the Kadiasans and Ammidians, four hundred and twenty-two; those from Kirama and Gabbes, six hundred and twenty-one; [21]

those from Macalon, a hundred and twenty-two; those from Betolio, fifty-two; the sons of Niphis, a hundred and fifty-six; 22 the sons of Kalamokalus and Onus, seven hundred and twenty-five; the sons of Jericho, two hundred and forty-five; 23 the sons of Sama,[o] three thousand three hundred and one.

24 The priests: the sons of Jeddu the son of Jeshua, of the sons of Sanabis, eight hundred and seventy-two; the sons of Emmerus,[p] two hundred and fifty-two; 25 the sons of Phassurus, one thousand two hundred and forty-seven; the sons of Charme, two hundred and seventeen. 26 The Levites: the sons of Jessue, of Kadmiel and Bannus and Sudius,[q] seventy-four. 27 The holy singers: the sons of Asaph, a hundred and twenty-eight. 28 The gatekeepers, four hundred;[r] the sons of Ishmael, the sons of Lacubatus, a thousand;[s] the sons of Tobis, in all a hundred and thirty-nine.

29 The temple servants:[t] the sons of Esau, the sons of Gasipha, the sons of Gabaoth, the sons of Keras, the sons of Sua, the sons of Phalaeus, the sons of Labana, 30 the sons of Akud, the sons of Uta, the sons of Ketab, the sons of Akkaba, the sons of Subai, the sons of Anan, the sons of Kua, the sons of Keddur, 31 the sons of Jairus, the sons of Daesan, the sons of Noeba, the sons of Chaseba, the sons of Kazera, the sons of Ozius, the sons of Phinoe, the sons of Asara, the sons of Basthai, the sons of Assana, the sons of Mani, the sons of Naphisi, the sons of Akuph, the sons of Achiba, the sons of Asur, the sons of Pharakem, the sons of Basalem, 32 the sons of Dedda, the sons of Bachus, the sons of Serar, the sons of Thomthi, the sons of Nasi, the sons of Atepha. 33 The sons of Solomon's servants: the sons of Assaphioth, the sons of Pharida, the sons of Jeieli, the sons of Lozon, the sons of Isdael, the sons of Saphuthi, 34 the sons of Agia, the sons of Phakareth Sabie, the sons of Sarothi, the sons of Misaias, the sons of Gas, the sons of Addus, the sons of Subas, the sons of Apherra, the sons of Barodis, the sons of Saphag, the sons of Allon. 35 The temple servants together with the sons of Solomon's servants numbered in all three hundred seventy and two.

36 These came up from Thermeleth and Thelersas, their leaders being Charaathalan and Allar;[u] 37 and they could not show their fathers'

houses and lineage, that they were of Israel: the sons of Asan the
son of Baenan, the sons of Nekodan, six hundred and fifty-two. 38
And of the priests, those who claimed the priesthood and were not
found: the sons of Obbia, the sons of Akbos, the sons of Jaddus, who
took Augia, one of the daughters of Phaezeldaeus,[v] as wife, and was
called by his name. 39 And when the record of their genealogy was
sought in the register and was not found, they were excluded from
serving as priests. 40 And Nehemiah and Attharias[w] charged them not
to partake of the holy things till there should rise up a priest clothed
with Manifestation and Truth.[x]
41 All those of Israel from twelve years old and upward, besides
menservants and maidservants, were forty-two thousand three hun-
dred and sixty;[y] their menservants and maidservants, seven thousand
three hundred and thirty-seven; male and female singers, two hun-
dred and forty-five; 42 camels, four hundred and thirty-five; and
horses, seven thousand and thirty-six;[z] mules, two hundred and forty-
five; beasts of burden, five thousand five hundred and twenty-five.
43 And some of the leaders of the fathers' houses, when they came to
the temple of God in Jerusalem, vowed to raise up the house again
on its own site according to their ability, 44 and to give to the holy
treasury for the works about 1,250 pounds of gold and about 6,250
pounds of silver,[aa] and a hundred priestly garments. 45 And the priests
and the Levites and some of the people settled in Jerusalem and the
country round, and the holy singers and the gatekeepers and all Israel
in their villages.
46 When the seventh month (September–October)[ab] was at hand, and
the sons of Israel were each in his own place, they gathered together
with one accord in the open square before the first gate toward the
east. 47 And Jeshua the son of Jozadak and his brothers the priests, and
Zerubbabel the son of Salathiel and his brothers, stood up and made
ready the altar of the God of Israel, 48 to offer burnt offerings upon it,
in accordance with what is laid down in the book of Moses the man of
God. 49 Some of the other peoples of the land gathered against them,[ac]
but they set up the altar in its original place, since all the peoples of
the land were hostile to them and stronger than they were; and they

offered sacrifices at the appointed times, and burnt offerings to the Lord each morning and evening. 50 And they kept the feast of booths, as it is commanded in the law, and offered sacrifices daily, as was fitting; 51 and after that the continual offerings, and the sacrifices of sabbaths and of new moons and of all the consecrated feasts. 52 And all who had made any vow to God began to offer sacrifices to God from the new moon of the first month (March–April),[ad] though the temple of God was not yet built. 53 They paid money to the masons and carpenters, and gave food, drink and oil to the Sidonians and Tyrians so that they would bring cedar logs from Lebanon and float them as rafts to the harbor at Joppa, as the decree of Cyrus, king of the Persians, had ordered.

54 And in the second year after his coming to the temple of God in Jerusalem, in the second month (April–May), Zerubbabel the son of Salathiel and Jeshua the son of Jozadak began, with their brothers and the Levitical priests and all who had come to Jerusalem from the captivity; 55 and they laid the foundation of the temple of God on the new moon of the second month in the second year after they had come to Judea and Jerusalem.[ae] 56 And they appointed the Levites from twenty years old and upward over the works of the Lord. And Jeshua stood up, with his sons and brothers, and Damadiel his brother,[af] and the sons of Jeshua Emadabun, and the sons of Judah the son of Iliadun, with their sons and brothers, all the Levites, with one accord as taskmasters, working at the tasks in the house of the Lord. And the builders built the temple of the Lord.

57 And the priests stood arrayed in their vestments, with musical instruments and trumpets, and the Levites, the sons of Asaph, with cymbals, singing hymns to the Lord and blessing him, after the manner of David king of Israel. 58 And they lifted up their voice with hymns, praising the Lord, "For his goodness and his glory endure for ever over all Israel."[ag] 59 And all the people sounded trumpets and shouted with a loud voice, singing hymns to the Lord for the raising up of the house of the Lord. 60 And some of the Levitical priests and of the heads of their fathers' houses, the old men who had seen the former house, came to the building of this one with crying out and

loud weeping, [61] and many with trumpets and great joy, with a loud voice, [62] so that the people could not distinguish the trumpets for the weeping of the people; for the multitude blew loud blasts, so that the noise was heard a great way off.
[63] And when the enemies of the tribe of Judah and Benjamin heard it, they came to learn what the sound of the trumpets meant. [64] And they learned that those who had come from the captivity were building the temple for the Lord God of Israel. [65] And they came to Zerubbabel and Jeshua and the leaders of the fathers' houses, and said to them, "We will build together with you. [66] For we too obey your Lord as you do, and have sacrificed to him from the days of Asbakaphath[ah] king of the Assyrians, who brought us over hither." [67] And Zerubbabel and Jeshua and the leaders of the fathers' houses of Israel said to them, "It is not for you to build the house for the Lord our God; [68] for we ourselves alone will build for the Lord of Israel, in accordance with what Cyrus the king of the Persians commanded us." [69] But the nations of the land pressed hard upon those in Judea, and by besieging them hindered them from building; [70] and by scheming, stirring up the people, and causing riots, they stopped the building for as long as King Cyrus lived; and the work was halted for two years, until the reign of Darius.[ai]

Notes

- a (5:5) Phinehas means "the Nubian" (an Egyptian name). 5:7–70 parallels Ezra 2:1–4:5 (compare Nehemiah 7:6–73), with many differences in the names and numbers; the names here follow Swete's Greek, and only some of the differences are noted.
- b (5:5) Greek "and Joakim the son of Zerubbabel," evidently a corrupt text; the sense required is "Jeshua … with Zerubbabel the son of Salathiel" (Ezra 3:2). Jeshua (Greek Iēsous) is the high priest Joshua of Haggai 1:1 and Zechariah 3:1; the name means "Yahweh saves." Salathiel is Shealtiel, "I have asked God." Phares is Perez (Genesis 38:29).
- c (5:6) Greek "in the month Nisan of the first month"; Nisan is the Babylonian name of the first month of the spring-start calendar.
- d (5:8) The list of leaders parallels Ezra 2:2 (Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, Baanah). Nehemiah means "Yahweh comforts"; Mardochaeus is Mordecai, a name derived from the Babylonian god Marduk.

- e (5:9) Swete's text reads "seventy-two thousand," apparently by the loss of part of the number; Ezra 2:3 has 2,172, which is followed here. Phoros is Parosh ("flea") in Ezra.
- f (5:11) So Swete; Ezra 2:6 has 2,812. Phaathmoab is Pahath-moab, "governor of Moab."
- g (5:12) Swete's text reads only "two," and part of the number has evidently been lost; Ezra 2:7 has "the sons of Elam, 1,254."
- h (5:13) Ezra 2:10–12 has "the sons of Bani (Bebai?), 623 ... the sons of Azgad, 1,222." Several Greek names and numbers in verses 12–23 differ from Ezra and Nehemiah.
- i (5:14) So Swete (37); Ezra 2:13 has 666, Nehemiah 7:18 has 667. Adonikam means "my Lord has risen."
- j (5:15) That is, Ater of Hezekiah (Ezra 2:16). Hezekiah means "Yahweh strengthens."
- k (5:16) No number is given in Swete's text for Arom or for Arsiphurith; some numbers have evidently been lost.
- l (5:17) Probably Ramah and Geba (Ezra 2:26), run together in the Greek, as also Kirama and Gabbes in verse 20 (compare Ezra 2:26–27). The Greek place-names in verses 17–23 are often corrupt.
- m (5:18) Swete's text gives no number here, and "Zammoth" may be a corruption of a number or a name (compare Azmaveth, Ezra 2:24).
- n (5:19) Kiriath-jearim ("city of forests") in Ezra 2:25. Beroth is Beeroth ("wells").
- o (5:23) Senaah in Ezra 2:35 (3,630). Jericho means "moon city" or "fragrant" (uncertain).
- p (5:24) Immer in Ezra 2:37. Phassurus is Pashhur.
- q (5:26) Ezra 2:40 has "Jeshua and Kadmiel, of the sons of Hodaviah."
- r (5:28) So Swete. Ezra 2:42 gives the gatekeepers as 139 in all (the sons of Shallum, Ater, Talmon, Akkub, Hatita, and Shobai); the Greek of this verse is confused.
- s (5:28) Swete's text reads "a thousand"; the clause is lacking in the parallel lists.
- t (5:29) Greek hierodouloi, "temple servants," the Nethinim ("given ones") of Ezra 2:43–58. Many of the following names differ in spelling from Ezra.
- u (5:36) In Ezra 2:59 Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addan, and Immer are place-names; the Greek has turned some of them into names of leaders.
- v (5:38) Barzillai the Gileadite (Ezra 2:61; 2 Samuel 19:31). The name means "man of iron."
- w (5:40) Hebrew hattirshata', "the governor" (Ezra 2:63), a Persian title which the Greek takes as a personal name; Nehemiah is not named in the parallel in Ezra 2:63.
- x (5:40) Greek tēn dēlōsin kai tēn alētheian, the Septuagint's rendering of the Urim and Thummim, the priestly lots worn in the breastpiece (Exodus 28:30).
- y (5:41) Ezra 2:64 and Nehemiah 7:66 give the whole assembly as 42,360; the figures listed do not add up to this total in any of the lists.
- z (5:42) So Swete; Ezra 2:66 has 736 horses.

- aa (5:44) Greek "a thousand minas of gold and five thousand minas of silver." A mina was 50 shekels, about 1¼ pounds (575 grams), so about 575 kilograms of gold and 2,875 kilograms of silver. Ezra 2:69 has 61,000 darics of gold and 5,000 minas of silver; Nehemiah 7:70–72 gives other figures.
- ab (5:46) Tishri, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 3:1).
- ac (5:49) Greek "And there were gathered to them some of the other nations of the land." The Greek of this verse is hard to interpret; compare Ezra 3:3, which gives a reason of fear of the surrounding peoples.
- ad (5:52) So Swete, "of the first month"; Ezra 3:6 has "from the first day of the seventh month," which suits the context better.
- ae (5:55) The second month is Iyyar or Ziv (April–May), on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 3:8).
- af (5:56) Kadmiel in Ezra 3:9. The names in this verse are confused in the Greek; "Emadabun" and "Iliadun" correspond to Henadad in Ezra 3:9.
- ag (5:58) Compare Ezra 3:11 and Psalm 136:1.
- ah (5:66) Esarhaddon king of Assyria (681–669 BC) in Ezra 4:2; the Greek form Asbakaphath is a corruption. Compare Ezra 4:10, Osnappar (Ashurbanipal).
- ai (5:70) Ezra 4:5 says "until the reign of Darius king of Persia." The narrative now resumes from 2:25.

Chapter 6

1 Now in the second year of the reign of Darius, Haggai and Zechariah
the son of Eddin,[a] the prophets, prophesied to the Jews in Judea and
Jerusalem in the name of the Lord God of Israel, which was upon
them.[b] 2 Then Zerubbabel the son of Salathiel and Jeshua the son of
Jozadak stood up and began to build the house of the Lord which is
in Jerusalem, the prophets of the Lord being with them and helping
them.
3 At the same time Sisinnes[c] the governor of Syria and Phoenicia came
to them, with Sathrabuzanes and their companions, and said to them,
4 "By whose appointment do you build this house and this roof, and
finish all the other things? And who are the builders that carry out
these things?" 5 Yet the elders of the Jews found favor, because the
Lord had visited the captivity;[d] 6 and they were not hindered from
building until word should be sent to Darius concerning them and an
answer returned.
7 A copy of the letter which Sisinnes the governor of Syria and
Phoenicia, and Sathrabuzanes, and their companions the rulers in

Syria and Phoenicia, wrote and sent to Darius:

"To King Darius, greeting.

8 May our lord the king be informed of everything: when we entered the land of Judea and came to the city of Jerusalem, we found that the Jewish elders, who had been in exile, were constructing a large new house for the Lord, built of costly cut stone, with timber set into the walls.[e]

9 And those works are being done with speed, and the work prospers in their hands, and it is being finished with all glory and diligence.

10 So we questioned those elders: 'On whose authority are you building this house and laying the foundations of this work?'

11 We questioned them therefore in order to make known to you and write to you the men who are the leaders, and we required of them a written list of the names of their chief men.

12 And they gave us this answer: 'We are servants of the Lord, the maker of heaven and earth.

13 And the house was built many years ago by a great and strong king of Israel, and was finished.

14 But when our fathers provoked the heavenly Lord of Israel and sinned against him, he gave them over into the hands of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, king of the Chaldeans;

15 and they pulled down the house and burned it, and carried the people captive to Babylon.

16 But in the first year that Cyrus ruled over Babylonia, King Cyrus ordered this house to be built.

17 And the holy vessels of gold and of silver, which Nebuchadnezzar had carried out of the house in Jerusalem and set up in his own temple, King Cyrus brought out again from the temple in Babylonia, and they were delivered to Zerubbabel and to Sanabassar the governor,

18 with the command that he should carry away all these vessels and put them in the temple at Jerusalem, and that the temple of the Lord should be built on its site.

19 Sanabassar then came and laid the foundations of the Lord's house in Jerusalem. Building has gone on from that time until now, and it is still not finished.'

20 Now therefore, O king, if it be judged good, let search be made in
the royal archives of our lord the king in Babylon;
21 and if it is found that the building of the house of the Lord in
Jerusalem was undertaken with the consent of King Cyrus, and if
our lord the king so decides, let him send us word concerning these
things."
22 Then King Darius commanded search to be made in the archives
that were laid up in Babylon; and there was found at Ecbatana,[f] the
fortress in the country of Media, a scroll in which this was recorded:
23 "In the first year of the reign of Cyrus, King Cyrus commanded that
the house of the Lord in Jerusalem be built, where they offer sacrifice
with perpetual fire, 24 its height to be about ninety feet and its breadth
about ninety feet,[g] built with three rows of polished stone and a row
of new timber of the country; and the cost to be paid out of the house
of King Cyrus; 25 and that the holy vessels of the house of the Lord,
both gold and silver, which Nebuchadnezzar carried out of the house
in Jerusalem and brought to Babylon, should be restored to the house
in Jerusalem where they had been placed, that they might be set
there." 26 And he commanded that Sisinnes the governor of Syria and
Phoenicia, and Sathrabuzanes, and their companions, and the rulers
appointed in Syria and Phoenicia, should take care to keep away from
the place, and leave Zerubbabel, the servant of the Lord and governor
of Judea, and the elders of the Jews, to build that house of the Lord
on its site. 27 "And I also command that it be built completely, and that
they look diligently to help those of the captivity of Judea until the
house of the Lord is finished; 28 and that out of the tribute of Coele-
Syria and Phoenicia a portion be carefully given to these men for
sacrifices to the Lord, to Zerubbabel the governor, for bulls and rams
and lambs; 29 and in like manner wheat, salt, wine, and oil, continually
year by year without question, as the priests in Jerusalem may direct
to be spent daily, 30 that drink offerings may be made to the Most High
God for the king and his children, and that they may pray for their
lives." 31 And he commanded that whoever should transgress or make
void any of the things written, a beam should be taken out of his
own house and he should be hanged upon it, and his goods should be

forfeited to the king. 32 "Therefore may the Lord, whose name is called upon there, destroy every king and nation that shall stretch out his hand to hinder or to do harm to that house of the Lord in Jerusalem. 33 I, Darius the king, have ordained that these things be done with care."

Notes

- a (6:1) Hebrew Iddo (Ezra 5:1; Zechariah 1:1, where Zechariah is the son of Berechiah, son of Iddo). Haggai means "festal"; Zechariah means "Yahweh remembers." 6:1–7:15 parallels Ezra 5:1–6:22.
- b (6:1) Greek "in the name of the Lord God of Israel upon them"; compare Ezra 5:1, "in the name of the God of Israel, who was over them."
- c (6:3) Hebrew Tattenai (Ezra 5:3), governor of the province Beyond the River, with Shethar-bozenai (Greek Sathrabuzanes).
- d (6:5) Greek "And the elders of the Jews had favor, a visitation having come upon the captivity from the Lord." Compare Ezra 5:5, "But the eye of their God was upon the elders of the Jews."
- e (6:8) Greek en tois oikois, "in the houses," probably meaning the walls or chambers.
- f (6:22) Ecbatana (Hebrew Achmetha, Ezra 6:2), the old capital of Media and a summer residence of the Persian kings; modern Hamadan in Iran.
- g (6:24) Greek "sixty cubits" in each case, about 27 meters. Ezra 6:3 also gives the height and breadth as sixty cubits; the dimensions are much larger than Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6:2) and may be an idealized or corrupted figure.

Chapter 7

1 Then Sisinnes the governor of Coele-Syria and Phoenicia, and Sathrabuzanes, and their companions, following the orders of King Darius, 2 took great care in overseeing the holy work, cooperating with the elders of the Jews and the chief officials of the temple. 3 And the holy works prospered, while Haggai and Zechariah the prophets prophesied. 4 And they finished these things by the command of the Lord God of Israel, and with the consent of Cyrus and Darius and Artaxerxes, kings of the Persians.[a] 5 And the house was finished by the twenty-third day of the month Adar (February–March),[b] in the sixth year of King Darius. 6 And the sons of Israel and the priests and the Levites and the rest of those from the captivity who had joined them did according to what is written in the book of Moses. 7 And for the dedication of the temple of the Lord they offered a hundred bulls, two hundred rams, four hundred lambs, 8 and twelve he-goats

for the sin of all Israel, according to the number of the twelve chiefs of the tribes of Israel. 9 And the priests and the Levites stood arrayed in their vestments by tribes, over the works of the Lord God of Israel, according to the book of Moses; and the gatekeepers were at every gate.
10 And the sons of Israel who were of the captivity kept the Passover on the fourteenth day of the first month (March–April),[c] when the priests and the Levites were purified together. 11 with all the sons of the captivity, for they were purified; for the Levites were all purified together.[d] 12 And they sacrificed the Passover for all the sons of the captivity, and for their brothers the priests, and for themselves. 13 The Israelites who had returned from exile ate it, together with everyone who had separated from the abominations of the peoples of the land and who sought the Lord. 14 And they kept the feast of unleavened bread seven days, making merry before the Lord, 15 because he had turned the counsel of the king of the Assyrians toward them, to strengthen their hands for the works of the Lord God of Israel.[e]

Notes

- a (7:4) Artaxerxes is named also in Ezra 6:14, although he reigned after the temple was finished; the reference anticipates the work of Ezra in his reign (chs. 8–9).
- b (7:5) Adar is the twelfth month of the spring-start calendar. Ezra 6:15 has "the third day of the month Adar." The sixth year of Darius was 516–515 BC.
- c (7:10) Nisan, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 6:19).
- d (7:11) The Greek is repetitive and somewhat confused; Ezra 6:20 says that the priests and the Levites had purified themselves together and were all clean.
- e (7:15) Compare Ezra 6:22, where "the king of Assyria" refers to the Persian ruler as successor to the Assyrian kings. From here 1 Esdras moves directly to the coming of Ezra (Ezra 7).

Chapter 8

1 After these things, when Artaxerxes[a] king of the Persians was reigning, there came Ezra[b] the son of Azariah, son of Zechrias,[c] son of Helkias, son of Salem, 2 son of Sadduk, son of Ahitub, son of Amarias, son of Ozias, son of Bokkas, son of Abisue, son of Phinehas, son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the chief priest. 3 This Ezra came up from Babylon as a scribe, an expert in the law of Moses given by the God of Israel. 4 And the king did him honor, for he found favor

before him in all his requests. 5 With him some of the Israelites went
up to Jerusalem: priests, Levites, gatekeepers, temple singers and
temple servants, 6 in the seventh year of the reign of Artaxerxes, in
the fifth month (July–August)[d] (the king's seventh year);[e] they had
left Babylon on the new moon of the first month (March–April) and
reached Jerusalem because of the successful journey the Lord granted
them for Ezra's sake. 7 For Ezra[f] possessed great knowledge, so that
he left out nothing of the things in the law of the Lord and in the
commandments, but taught all Israel the statutes and the judgments.
8 Now the commission which King Artaxerxes sent to Ezra the priest
and reader of the law of the Lord came to him, and this following
is a copy of it: 9 "King Artaxerxes to Ezra the priest and reader of
the law of the Lord, greeting. 10 Having resolved to show kindness,
I have ordered that any of the Jewish nation, and of the priests and
Levites and the rest within our kingdom, who are willing and choose
it, shall journey with you to Jerusalem. 11 Let as many therefore as are
so minded set out with you, as it has seemed good to me and to my
seven friends the counselors, 12 that they may look into the affairs of
Judea and Jerusalem, in keeping with what is in the law of the Lord, 13
and take to Jerusalem the gifts for the Lord that I and my friends have
promised, along with all the gold and silver for the Lord that may be
found in the land of Babylonia, and whatever the people have given
for the temple of their Lord in Jerusalem, 14 collect all of it, gold and
silver, for buying bulls, rams, lambs and the offerings that go with
them, 15 so that sacrifices may be offered upon the altar of their Lord
in Jerusalem. 16 And whatever you and your brothers wish to do with
the gold and silver, perform it according to the will of your God. 17
And deliver the holy vessels of the Lord which are given to you for
the use of the temple of your God in Jerusalem.[g] And whatever else
occurs to you as needed for the temple of your God, 18 you shall pay
for it out of the king's treasury. 19 And I, King Artaxerxes, hereby
order the treasurers of Syria and Phoenicia to give Ezra the priest,
the reader of the law of the Most High God, whatever he asks for,
with diligence, up to about seventy-five hundred pounds of silver,[h]
20 and likewise up to about six hundred fifty bushels of wheat and a

thousand gallons of wine,[i] 21 Let everything be fulfilled for the Most
High God as the law of God directs, lest wrath fall on the realm of
the king and his sons. 22 It is also announced to you that no tribute
or other burden may be imposed on any priest, Levite, temple singer,
gatekeeper, temple servant, or anyone working in this temple, and
that no one has the authority to levy any tax on them. 23 And you,
Ezra, according to the wisdom of God, appoint judges and magistrates
to judge throughout all Syria and Phoenicia all those who know the
law of your God; and those who do not know it you shall teach. 24 And
all who transgress the law of your God and of the king shall be duly
punished, whether by death or by other penalty, whether by fine of
money or by imprisonment."[j]
25 Blessed be the Lord alone, who put these things into the heart of the
king, to glorify his house which is in Jerusalem, 26 and who honored
me in the sight of the king and his counselors and all his friends and
nobles. 27 So I was encouraged by the help of the Lord my God, and
gathered men from Israel to go up with me.
28 And these are the leaders according to their fathers' houses and
their divisions, who went up with me from Babylon in the reign of
King Artaxerxes:[k] 29 Of the sons of Phinehas, Gershom; of the sons
of Ithamar, Gamael;[l] of the sons of David, Hattush[m] the son of Shecaniah; 30 of the sons of Parosh, Zechariah, and with him by register a
hundred fifty men; 31 of the sons of Pahath-moab, Eliehoenai the son
of Zerahiah, and with him two hundred men; 32 of the sons of Zathoes,
Jeconiah the son of Jethelus, and with him two hundred men; of the
sons of Adin, Obed the son of Jonathan, and with him two hundred
fifty men; 33 of the sons of Elam, Jeshaiah the son of Athaliah,[n] and
with him seventy men; 34 of the sons of Shephatiah, Zeraiah the son
of Michael, and with him seventy men; 35 of the sons of Joab, Obadiah
the son of Jehiel, and with him two hundred twelve men; 36 from the
descendants of Bani, Shelomith son of Josiphiah, and with him one
hundred sixty men; 37 of the sons of Bebai, Zechariah the son of Bebai,
and with him twenty-eight men; 38 of the sons of Azgad, Johanan the
son of Hakkatan, and with him a hundred ten men; 39 of the sons of
Adonikam, the last ones, and these are their names: Eliphelet, Jeuel,

and Shemaiah, and with them seventy men; 40 of the sons of Bigvai, Uthai the son of Istacalcus, and with him seventy men.
41 And I assembled them by the river named Theras,[o] and there we lay in camp three days, and I reviewed them. 42 And when I found there none of the priests or of the Levites, 43 I sent for these leaders and men of learning: Eleazar, Iduel, Maasmas, Elnathan, Shemaiah, Jarib, Nathan, Elnathan, Zechariah, Meshullam; 44 and I bade them go to Iddo,[p] the chief man in the place of the treasury, 45 charging them to speak with Iddo and his kinsmen and the treasurers there, that they should send us such as might minister as priests in our Lord's house.
46 And they brought us a man of understanding, Sherebiah, from the sons of Mahli,[q] the descendant of Levi the son of Israel, with his sons and kinsmen, ten; 47 and of the sons of Chanuneus[r] and their sons, twenty men; 48 and from the temple servants whom David and the leaders had assigned to assist the Levites, two hundred twenty temple servants; a record of all their names was submitted.
49 And there I vowed a fast for the young men before our Lord, 50 to seek from him a prosperous journey for us and for our children and our cattle that were with us. 51 For I was ashamed to ask the king for horsemen and foot soldiers as an escort, to keep us safe against our adversaries; 52 for we had told the king, "The might of our Lord shall be with them that seek him, to set all things right."[s] 53 And again we besought our Lord concerning all these things, and found him very merciful.
54 Then I set apart twelve men of the chiefs of the priests, Sherebiah and Hashabiah, and with them ten men of their brothers; 55 and I weighed out to them the silver and the gold and the holy vessels of the house of our Lord, which the king and his counselors and the nobles and all Israel had given. 56 And when I had weighed it, I delivered to them about forty-nine thousand pounds of silver, and silver vessels weighing about seventy-five hundred pounds, and about seventy-five hundred pounds of gold,[t] and twenty gold vessels, and ten[u] bronze vessels of fine bronze that glittered like gold. 57 And I said to them, "You yourselves are holy to the Lord, and the vessels are holy, and the silver and the gold are a vow to the Lord, the Lord of our fathers.

58 Watch and keep them until you hand them over in Jerusalem to the
chiefs of the priests and Levites and the heads of Israel's families, in
the chambers of our Lord's house." 59 So the priests and the Levites
who received the silver and the gold and the vessels which had been
in Jerusalem[v] brought them into the temple of the Lord.
60 And we set out from the river Theras on the twelfth day of the
first month (March–April),[w] and came to Jerusalem by the mighty
hand of our Lord, which was upon us; and from the beginning of our
journey the Lord delivered us from every enemy, and so we came
to Jerusalem. 61 When we had been there three days, the silver and
gold were weighed and handed over in the house of our Lord to the
priest Meremoth, the son of Uriah;[x] 62 and with him was Eleazar the
son of Phinehas, and with them were Jozabad the son of Jeshua and
Moeth the son of Binnui, the Levites. All was delivered by number
and weight, and the whole weight was recorded at that very hour. 63
And those who had come out of the captivity offered sacrifices to the
Lord, the God of Israel: twelve bulls for all Israel,[y] ninety-six rams,
seventy-six[z] lambs, and twelve goats for a peace offering, all as a
sacrifice to the Lord. 64 And they handed over the king's commands to
the king's stewards and the governors of Coele-Syria and Phoenicia;
and these honored the nation and the temple of the Lord.
65 Now when this was finished, the chief men approached me, saying,
66 "Neither the nation of Israel nor the princes nor the priests nor
the Levites have separated from them the foreign peoples of the land
with their uncleanness, the Canaanites, Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites,
Moabites, Egyptians, and Edomites. 67 For they and their sons have
married the daughters of these peoples, and the holy seed has been
mixed with the foreign peoples of the land; and from the start the
leaders and nobles have taken part in this lawlessness."
68 As soon as I heard this, I tore my clothes and my holy robe, pulled
hair from my head and beard, and sat down, disturbed and full of
grief. 69 Everyone who had ever been stirred by the word of the Lord of
Israel gathered around me while I mourned this lawlessness, and I sat
grieving until the evening sacrifice.[aa] 70 Then I rose from my fasting,

with my garments and my holy robe torn, and bowing my knees and stretching out my hands to the Lord, I said,
71 "O Lord, I am ashamed and confounded before your face. 72 For our sins have multiplied above our heads, and our errors have risen up to heaven 73 ever since our fathers' days; and to this day we are deep in sin. 74 And for our sins and our fathers' sins, we together with our brothers, our kings, and our priests were handed over to the earth's kings, for the sword, for exile, and for plunder with disgrace, until this very day. 75 And now, how great is the mercy that has come to us from you, O Lord,[ab] that there should be left to us a root and a name in your holy place, 76 and that you would reveal a light to us in the house of the Lord our God, and give us food in this time of slavery! 77 Even while we were slaves our Lord did not forsake us, but gave us grace before the Persian kings, so that they gave us food 78 and glorified the temple of our Lord, and raised up desolate Zion, to give us a sure dwelling in Judea and Jerusalem. 79 And now, O Lord, what shall we say, having these things? For we have transgressed your commandments, which you gave by your servants the prophets, saying, 80 'The land which you are entering to possess is a land defiled with the pollution of the aliens of the land, and they have filled it with their uncleanness. 81 Therefore you shall not give your daughters to their sons, nor take their daughters for your sons; 82 and you must never seek peace with them, so that you may be strong, enjoy the good things of the land, and leave it as an inheritance to your children forever.' 83 And everything that has happened to us has come because of our evil deeds and great sins. For you, Lord, have eased the weight of our sins 84 and gave us such a root as this; yet we have turned back again to transgress your law by mingling with the uncleanness of the nations of the land. 85 Were you not angry enough with us to destroy us, until you left us neither root nor seed nor name?[ac] 86 O Lord of Israel, you are true; for we are left a root this day. 87 Behold, we are now before you in our lawlessness; for we can no longer stand before you because of these things."
88 And while Ezra was praying and making his confession, weeping and lying upon the ground before the temple, there gathered to him

from Jerusalem a very great crowd, men and women and youths; for there was great weeping among the multitude. [89] Then Jeconiah son of Jeelus, one of the Israelites, spoke up and said to Ezra, "We have sinned against the Lord by marrying foreign women from the peoples of the land; yet there is still hope for all Israel.[ad] [90] Let us swear an oath to the Lord about this, that we will send away all our foreign wives and their children, as you have decided, along with everyone who obeys the law of the Lord. [91] Rise up and carry it out; for the matter rests with you, and we are with you to act with strength." [92] Then Ezra rose and put the leaders of the priests and Levites of all Israel under oath to do these things; and they swore to it.

Notes

- a (8:1) Artaxerxes (Persian Artakhshassa, perhaps "whose rule is through truth"), most likely Artaxerxes I (465–424 BC), although some date Ezra's mission under Artaxerxes II (404–358 BC). 8:1–9:36 parallels Ezra 7:1–10:44.
- b (8:1) Ezra means "help." The Greek form Esdras, used in the title of the book, renders the same name.
- c (8:1) The genealogy parallels Ezra 7:1–5 (Seraiah, Azariah, Hilkiah, Shallum, Zadok, Ahitub, Amariah, Azariah, Meraioth, and then Zerahiah, Uzzi, Bukki, Abishua, Phinehas, Eleazar, Aaron); the Greek forms are kept here. Aaron perhaps means "enlightened" or "mountaineer" (uncertain).
- d (8:6) Greek "in the fifth month," that is, Av, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 7:8). The seventh year of Artaxerxes I is 458 BC.
- e (8:6) Greek "this was the second year for the king," evidently a corruption; Ezra 7:8 has "the seventh year of the king."
- f (8:7) Swete's Greek reads Apsaros here, a corruption of the name Ezra.
- g (8:17) Greek "and according to your holy vessels given…"; Ezra 7:19 reads "the vessels that are given to you … deliver before the God of Jerusalem."
- h (8:19) Greek "up to a hundred talents of silver." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg), so a hundred talents is about 7,500 pounds (3,400 kg).
- i (8:20) Greek "up to a hundred kors of wheat and a hundred measures (metrētai) of wine." A kor was about 6½ bushels (about 220 liters); a metrētēs was about 10 gallons (39 liters). Ezra 7:22 adds a hundred baths of oil and salt without limit.
- j (8:24) Greek "not by fine of money or imprisonment," apparently a corruption; Ezra 7:26 lists "death, banishment, confiscation of goods, or imprisonment."
- k (8:28) Here the narrative changes to the first person (Ezra's own memoir), as in Ezra 7:27–9:15. The names in verses 29–48 are given in the forms of Ezra 8:1–20 where Swete's Greek is plainly the same name (Swete has, for example, Phoros

for Phinehas, Gamelos, Phares for Parosh, and Elialonias Zaraiou); the remaining Greek forms are kept.

- l (8:29) Gershom means "a stranger there" (Exodus 2:22); Ithamar perhaps means "land of palms"; Gamael corresponds to Daniel in Ezra 8:2.
- m (8:29) Swete's Greek lacks the name and reads "of the sons of David, Phares, Zacharias"; Hattush the son of Shecaniah is supplied from Ezra 8:2–3 (other Greek copies reportedly have it as well). Hattush was a descendant of Zerubbabel (1 Chronicles 3:22).
- n (8:33) Greek "Esias son of Gotholias," the Jeshaiah son of Athaliah of Ezra 8:7.
- o (8:41) Greek Thera (Ezra 8:15, 21, 31, Ahava), an unidentified river or canal near Babylon.
- p (8:44) Greek Laadaios and Lodaios (the same man), Iddo in Ezra 8:17, the leader at Casiphia; the Greek has "the place of the treasury."
- q (8:46) Mahli means "sickly" or perhaps "shrewd." Swete has the single name Asebebias for Sherebiah (Ezra 8:18).
- r (8:47) Greek Chanunaios. Ezra 8:19 has "Hashabiah, and with him Jeshaiah of the sons of Merari, with his brothers and their sons, twenty"; other Greek copies reportedly have a longer text naming Hashabiah, Annunus, and Jeshaiah.
- s (8:52) Greek "for all restoration" (eis pasan epanorthōsin); compare Ezra 8:22, where God's hand is on everyone who seeks him for good.
- t (8:56) Greek "six hundred fifty talents of silver, and silver vessels of a hundred talents, and a hundred talents of gold." At about 75 pounds (34 kg) to the talent, these are about 48,750 pounds (22,100 kg) of silver, about 7,500 pounds (3,400 kg) of silver vessels, and about 7,500 pounds of gold (compare Ezra 8:26).
- u (8:56) So Swete; other Greek copies reportedly read "twelve." Ezra 8:27 has "two vessels of fine bright bronze, precious as gold."
- v (8:59) Greek "the vessels in Jerusalem"; the sense is that they received them to carry to Jerusalem.
- w (8:60) Greek "on the twelfth day of the first month," that is, Nisan, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 8:31).
- x (8:61) Uriah means "Yahweh is my light." Swete has "Marmoth Ouria" (Ezra 8:33, Meremoth the son of Uriah).
- y (8:63) Swete's text as transcribed lacks "twelve bulls for all Israel … rams," reading only "ninety-six"; the words are supplied from Ezra 8:35.
- z (8:63) So Swete; Ezra 8:35 has seventy-seven.
- aa (8:69) The evening offering, about 3 p.m. (the ninth hour from 6 a.m.), when Ezra 9:5 also says he rose from his fasting.
- ab (8:75) Greek "from the Lord Lord" (kyriou Kyriou), perhaps a scribal doubling; Ezra 9:8 has "from Yahweh our God."
- ac (8:85) Greek "You were not angry with us so as to destroy us…," a statement; compare Ezra 9:14, which is a question. The question form is followed here.

- ad (8:89) Greek "and now all Israel is above," a corrupt phrase; Ezra 10:2 has "yet now there is hope for Israel concerning this thing."

Chapter 9

1 Then Ezra rose from the court of the temple and went to the chamber
of Jehohanan the son of Eliashib,[a] 2 and he lodged there, and ate no
bread and drank no water, mourning over the great lawlessness of the
multitude. 3 And a proclamation was made throughout all Judea and
Jerusalem to all who were of the captivity, that they should assemble
at Jerusalem; 4 and that whoever did not meet them within two or
three days, according to the decision of the elders who presided,
should have his cattle devoted to the temple,[b] and he himself should
be cut off from the multitude of the captivity.
5 So within three days the men of Judah and Benjamin came together
at Jerusalem; it was the twentieth of the ninth month (November–
December).[c] 6 And all the multitude sat together in the open square
of the temple, shivering because of the winter that had set in.[d] 7 Ezra
stood up and said to them, "You have broken the law by marrying
foreign wives, and so you have added to Israel's sin. 8 And now make
confession and give glory to the Lord God of our fathers, 9 and do his
will, and separate yourselves from the nations of the land and from
the foreign women." 10 The whole crowd then shouted with a loud
voice, "We will do as you say. 11 But the crowd is large, it is winter, and
we cannot stand outside; we have found no shelter;[e] and this is not
a job for one day or two, because we have committed a great sin in
this matter. 12 So let the leaders of the assembly stay, and let everyone
from our towns who has a foreign wife come at set times, 13 with
the elders and judges of each place, until we turn away the wrath of
the Lord from us over this matter." 14 Jonathan the son of Asahel and
Jahzeiah the son of Tikvah[f] undertook the business accordingly, with
Meshullam, Levi, and Shabbethai sitting as umpires alongside them.
15 And those of the captivity did according to all these things.
16 And Ezra the priest chose for himself men who were heads of their
fathers' houses, all of them by name; and they sat down together on
the new moon of the tenth month (December–January)[g] to examine

the matter. 17 The cases of the men who had foreign wives were finished by the new moon of the first month (March–April).[h]
18 And of the priests who had come together and were found to have foreign wives there were: 19 of the sons of Jeshua the son of Jozadak and his brothers, Maaseiah, Eleazar, Jarib, and Jodan.[i] 20 And they gave their hands[j] to put away their wives, and to offer rams in atonement for their error. 21 And of the sons of Immer: Hanani, Zabdaeus, Manes, Samaeus, Hiereel, and Azariah. 22 And of the sons of Pashhur: Elionai, Massias, Ishmael, Nathanael, Ocidelus, and Salthas.[k] 23 And of the Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah (that is, Kelita), Pethahiah, Judah, and Jonas. 24 Of the temple singers: Eliashib and Bacchurus.[l] 25 Of the gatekeepers: Shallum and Tolbanes. 26 Of Israel, of the sons of Parosh: Hiermas, Jeddias, Malchijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Hashabiah, and Benaiah.[m] 27 Of the sons of Elam: Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jezrielus, Obadiah, Jeremoth, and Elijah. 28 And of the sons of Zamoth: Eliadas, Eliashib, Othoniah, Jerimoth, Sabathus, and Zeralias. 29 And of the sons of Bebai: Johanan, Hananiah, Zabdus, and Emathis. 30 And of the sons of Mani: Olamus, Mamuchus, Jedaeus, Jashub, Asaelus, and Jeremoth. 31 And of the sons of Addi: Naathus, Moossias, Laccunus, Naidus, Bescaspasmys, Sesthel, Balnuus, and Manasseas.[n] 32 And of the sons of Annan: Elionas, Asaeas, Malchijah, Sabbaeas, and Simon Chosamaeus. 33 And of the sons of Hashum: Maltannaeus, Mattathias, Sabannaeus, Eliphalat, Manasseh, Semei. 34 And of the sons of Bani: Jeremai, Momdis, Maerus, Joel, Mamdai, Bedeiah, Vaniah, Carabasion, Enasibus, Mamnitanaemus, Eliasis, Binnui, Elialis, Shimei, Shelemiah, and Nethaniah. And of the sons of Ezora: Shashai, Azarel, Azael, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Joseph.[o] 35 Of the sons of Nooma: Mazitias, Zabadaeas, Iddo, Joel, and Benaiah. 36 Every one of these had taken foreign wives, and they sent them away with the children.[p]
37 And the priests and the Levites and those of Israel settled in Jerusalem and in the country. On the new moon of the seventh month (September–October),[q] when the sons of Israel were in their settlements, 38 the whole multitude came together as one man into the broad place before the temple gate toward the east;[r] 39 and they bade Ezra, priest and reader, fetch the law of Moses that the God of

Israel had handed down. 40 So Ezra the chief priest[s] brought the law
to all the multitude, both men and women, and to all the priests, that
they might hear the law, on the new moon of the seventh month.
41 And from early morning until noon he read in the broad place in
front of the temple gate, before men and women alike; and they gave
all their attention to the law. 42 And Ezra the priest and reader of
the law stood upon the wooden platform which had been made for
the purpose; 43 and there stood beside him on his right Mattathias,
Sammus, Hananiah, Azariah, Uriah, Hezekiah, and Baalsamus; 44 and
on his left Phaldaeus, Mishael, Malchijah, Lothasubus, Nabariah, and
Zechariah. 45 Then Ezra took up the book in the sight of the multitude,
for he sat in the place of honor in the sight of all; 46 and when he
opened the law, they all stood upright. And Azariah[t] blessed the Lord,
the Most High God, the God of hosts, the Almighty;[u] 47 and all the
multitude answered, "Amen, amen!" And lifting up their hands they
fell to the ground and worshiped the Lord. 48 Jeshua, Anniuth, Sara-
bias, Jadinus, Jarsubus, Abtaeus, Autaeas, Maiannas, Calitas, Azarias,
Jozabdus, Annias, Phalias, the Levites, taught the law of the Lord, and
read the law of the Lord to the multitude, at the same time giving the
sense of what was read.[v]

49 And Attharates[w] spoke to Ezra, high priest and reader, and to the
Levites who instructed the people, and to everyone: 50 "This day is
holy to the Lord"; for they were all weeping as they heard the law.[x]
51 "Go then, and eat the fat and drink the sweet, and send portions to
those who have none; 52 for this day is holy to the Lord; do not be sad,
for the Lord will glorify you." 53 The Levites likewise gave charge to
the whole people: "This day is holy; be not grieved." 54 Then they all
went their way to eat and drink and make merry, and to give portions
to those who had none, and to rejoice greatly; 55 for the words they
had been taught had filled them with fervor. And they came together.[y]

Notes

- a (9:1) Greek "the chamber of Jonas the son of Naseibos" (Swete); Ezra 10:6 has Jehohanan the son of Eliashib, whose names are followed here. Jehohanan means "Yahweh is gracious"; Eliashib means "God restores."

- b (9:4) Greek "devoted" or "consecrated" (aniĕrōthēsontai), that is, forfeited to the sanctuary; compare Ezra 10:8, "all his property should be forfeited."
- c (9:5) Greek "this was the ninth month, on the twentieth of the month," that is, Kislev, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 10:9).
- d (9:6) Greek "trembling because of the present winter"; Ezra 10:9 adds "because of this matter and because of the heavy rain." Kislev falls in the rainy season.
- e (9:11) Greek "and we have not found (it)," an obscure phrase; the sense may be that they have not been able to complete the task, or that there is no shelter.
- f (9:14) Greek "Jonathas son of Azaelus and Ezekias son of Thokanos"; the names follow Ezra 10:15. Jonathan means "Yahweh has given"; Tikvah means "hope." In Ezra 10:15 these men oppose the plan; here they carry it out.
- g (9:16) Greek "on the new moon of the tenth month," that is, Tevet, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 10:16).
- h (9:17) Greek "until the new moon of the first month," that is, Nisan, on the spring-start calendar (Ezra 10:17). The examination thus took about three months.
- i (9:19) Greek Maeēlas, Eleazaros, Ioribos, Iōdanos; the forms of Ezra 10:18 (Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, Gedaliah) are partly followed. 9:18–36 parallels the list of Ezra 10:18–44; many names differ, and the Greek forms are generally kept in this list.
- j (9:20) That is, they pledged themselves (Ezra 10:19).
- k (9:22) Swete's forms are Phaisur, Elionais, Asseias, Ismaelos, Nathanaelos, Okaildos, Salthas; compare Ezra 10:22 (Pashhur, Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, Elasah).
- l (9:24) Swete has Eliasebos and Bakchouros; Ezra 10:24 names only Eliashib among the singers.
- m (9:26) Swete has Phoros (Parosh), Ierma, Iezeias, Melcheias, Milelos, Eleazaros, Asebeias, Bannaias; compare Ezra 10:25.
- n (9:31) Swete has Addein; Ezra 10:30 has Pahath-moab. The Greek list in this verse differs considerably from Ezra.
- o (9:34) In Swete the list runs to the end of verse 35, and the sons of Ezora are part of verse 34. Swete's forms here include Ierēmias, Momdeios, Maēros, Iouna, Mamdai, Pedias, Anōs, Karabaseion, Enaseibos, Mamtanaimos, Eliaseis, Bannous, Edialeis, Someeis, Selemias, Nathanias; and for the sons of Ezora, Seseis, Ezreil, Azaēlos, Samatos, Zambrei, Phosēpos. Some forms are adapted toward Ezra 10:34–42.
- p (9:36) Greek "and they sent them away with children." Ezra 10:44 ends with an obscure Hebrew clause, often rendered "and some of the wives had borne children."
- q (9:37) Greek "on the new moon of the seventh month," that is, Tishri, on the spring-start calendar. 9:37–55 parallels Nehemiah 7:73–8:12. In 1 Esdras, Nehemiah does not appear in this scene; see the note on verse 49.
- r (9:38) Nehemiah 8:1 has "the square before the Water Gate."
- s (9:40) Greek archiereus, "high priest"; in Nehemiah 8:2 Ezra is called "the priest."
- t (9:46) Azariah is not in Nehemiah 8:6, where Ezra himself blesses the Lord; Azariah has been named among those standing beside him (verse 43).

- u (9:46) Greek Pantokratōr, “ruler of all,” the Septuagint word for the Hebrew Sabaoth (“of hosts”) and Shaddai; “Almighty” renders it in this translation. Swete reads simply “the Most High God, the Almighty”; “the Lord … the God of hosts” follows Nehemiah 8:6 and other Greek copies, as reported.
- v (9:48) Greek emphysiountes, literally “breathing into” the reading, that is, making it come alive and giving its meaning (compare Nehemiah 8:8, “they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading”).
- w (9:49) Greek Attharatēs, a corrupt form of the Persian title tirshatha, “governor,” given to Nehemiah in Nehemiah 8:9 (compare 1 Esdras 5:40, Attharias). 1 Esdras treats it as a personal name.
- x (9:50) Nehemiah 8:9 has “Do not mourn or weep,” and explains, “for all the people wept when they heard the words of the law.”
- y (9:55) The book ends abruptly in the middle of the Nehemiah narrative (Nehemiah 8:12–13). The last words, “And they assembled together,” correspond to the start of Nehemiah 8:13 and suggest that the end of the book has been lost; the work may originally have continued with the Feast of Booths. Josephus, who used 1 Esdras for his account of this period (Antiquities 11), reportedly continues the story to Ezra’s death.

2 Esdras

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

The Second Book of Ezra the Prophet

1 The second book of the prophet Ezra,[b] the son of Sareus, the son
of Azareus, the son of Helcias, the son of Sadanias, the son of Sadoc,
the son of Achitob, 2 the son of Achias, the son of Phinees, the son of
Heli, the son of Amerias, the son of Asiel, the son of Marimoth, the
son of Arna, the son of Ozias, the son of Borith, the son of Abiseus,
the son of Phinees, the son of Eleazar, 3 a descendant of Aaron from
the tribe of Levi, who was held captive in the land of the Medes when
Artaxerxes was king of Persia.[c]
4 And this word from the Lord[d] came to me: 5 "Go and tell my people
about their crimes, and tell their children about the wrongs they have
done to me, so that they can pass it on to their grandchildren; 6 for the
sins of their parents have grown great in them; they have forgotten
me and offered sacrifice to foreign gods. 7 Was it not I who brought
them out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery? Yet they
have provoked me to anger and scorned my counsels. 8 But you, pull
the hair from your head[e] and heap every evil on them, for they have
not obeyed my law; they are a people who will not take correction.
9 How long shall I bear with them, on whom I have bestowed such
great benefits? 10 On their account I overturned many kings; Pharaoh,
together with his servants and his whole host, I struck down. 11
I destroyed all the nations before them; and in the east I scattered
the peoples of two provinces, Tyre and Sidon,[f] and I killed all their
enemies.
12 "But you, speak to them and say, 'Thus says the Lord: 13 It was I
who brought you through the sea and made you walled roads where
there were none.[g] I gave you Moses as your leader and Aaron as your

priest; 14 I gave you light with a pillar of fire and did great wonders
among you. And still you have forgotten me, says the Lord.
15 "'Thus says the Lord Almighty: The quail was a sign to you; I gave
you a camp for your protection, and there you grumbled. 16 You did
not exult in my name at the destruction of your enemies, but even
to this day you still grumble. 17 What has become of the kindnesses I
showed you? In the desert, when hunger came on you, did you not
cry aloud to me 18 saying, "Why did you bring us into this wilderness
to kill us? We would have been better off serving the Egyptians than
dying in this wilderness." 19 I felt pity at your groaning and gave you
manna to eat; you ate the bread of angels. 20 When thirst came on
you, was it not I who cut open the rock, and waters ran out until you
had your fill? Against the burning heat I sheltered you with leaves
from the trees.[h] 21 I divided fertile lands among you; I drove out the
Canaanites and the Perizzites and the Philistines before you. What
more shall I do for you? says the Lord.
22 "'Thus says the Lord Almighty: When you were in the wilderness
at the river of the Amorites,[i] thirsty and blaspheming my name, 23 I
sent no fire on you in return for your blasphemies, but cast a piece
of wood into the water and turned the river sweet. 24 What shall I do
to you, Jacob? You would not obey, Judah. I will turn to other nations
and give them my name, so that they may keep my statutes. 25 Because
you have forsaken me, I also will forsake you. When you ask me for
mercy, I will show you none. 26 When you cry out to me, I will not
listen; your hands are stained with blood, and your feet are quick to
commit murder. 27 Yet it is not I that you have abandoned, but your
own selves, says the Lord.
28 "'Thus says the Lord Almighty: Have I not pleaded with you as a
father pleads with his sons, or a mother with her daughters, or a nurse
with her little ones, 29 that you should be my people and I your God,
that you should be my children and I your father? 30 I gathered you as
a hen gathers her chicks under her wings.[j] But now, what shall I do
to you? I will cast you out from my presence. 31 When you bring me
offerings, I will turn my face from you; for I have rejected your feast
days and new moons and circumcisions. 32 I sent you my servants

the prophets, and you took them and killed them and mutilated their bodies; I will require their blood, says the Lord.
33 "'This is what the Lord Almighty says: Your house is left a desert. I will toss you away as the wind tosses stubble; 34 and your children will have no offspring, because they have neglected my commandment and done what is evil in my sight. 35 I will hand over your houses to a people that is coming, who will believe though they have not heard me; to whom I have shown no signs, yet they will do what I have commanded. 36 They have not seen the prophets, yet they will call to mind the wrongs of those before them.[k] 37 I call to witness the gratitude of the people that is coming, whose little ones leap for joy; they do not see me with bodily eyes, yet in spirit they believe what I have said.
38 "'And now, brother,[l] behold the glory, and look upon the people that comes from the sunrise; 39 I will grant them for guides Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, Hosea, Amos, Micah, Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, 40 Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, whom men also call the angel of the Lord.' "[m]

Notes

- a (1:0) Chapters 1–2 are a later Christian addition to the book, often called 5 Ezra (Fifth Ezra); they are written as a prophecy of Ezra rejecting Israel in favor of a people "coming from the east" and are generally dated to the 2nd or 3rd century AD. They are preserved only in Latin, in two forms (a "French" and a "Spanish" family of manuscripts, as reported); this translation follows the Clementine Vulgate text, with significant differences noted. See the introduction to the book.
- b (1:1) Ezra means "help." The genealogy follows Ezra 7:1–5 with additions (Ahijah, Eli, Aziel, Arna, Borith; compare 1 Chronicles 6:4–14). Seraiah means "Yahweh contends"; Hilkiah, "Yahweh is my portion"; Zadok, "righteous"; Phinehas is an Egyptian name, "the Nubian"; Eleazar means "God has helped." The names are given here in their Latin forms: Sareus is Seraiah, Azareus Azariah, Helcias Hilkiah, Sadanias perhaps Shallum, Sadoc Zadok, Achitob Ahitub, Achias Ahijah, Phinees Phinehas, Heli Eli, Amerias Amariah, Marimoth Meraioth, Ozias Uzzi, and Abiseus Abishua.
- c (1:3) Artaxerxes (Persian Artakhshassa) was the king under whom Ezra came to Jerusalem (Ezra 7:1). The statement that Ezra was a captive in Media is found only here.

- d (1:4) Latin Dominus, "Lord." In this book, which survives from the Latin, "Lord" renders Dominus throughout, and "the Lord Almighty" renders Dominus omnipotens.
- e (1:8) A sign of grief and anger; compare Ezra 9:3.
- f (1:11) Latin "the peoples of two provinces, Tyre and Sidon"; the text is uncertain, and some manuscripts reportedly lack the names.
- g (1:13) Latin "I showed you streets (or broad ways) fortified from the beginning"; compare Exodus 14:22, where the waters were a wall on either side.
- h (1:20) An addition to the Exodus story, not found in the Hebrew Bible; compare Wisdom 19:7 and the shade of Psalm 105:39 (Septuagint 104:39).
- i (1:22) Latin "in the river of the Amorites"; the story is that of Marah (Exodus 15:22–25), and the location is uncertain.
- j (1:30) Compare Matthew 23:37 and Luke 13:34; chapters 1–2 contain many echoes of the New Testament.
- k (1:36) Latin "and they will remember their iniquities," that is, perhaps, the new people will recall the sins of Israel; the sense is debated, and other manuscripts reportedly read differently.
- l (1:38) Latin frater, "brother," in the Clementine text; other manuscripts reportedly have pater, "father," which fits 2:5. The Lord addresses Ezra. Latin "see what glory," perhaps "see with pride."
- m (1:40) Malachi means "my messenger" (Malachi 3:1); the Latin adds that he "is also called the angel of the Lord," reflecting a tradition, found also in the Targum, that the prophet was an angel or identifying him with Ezra himself. The twelve Minor Prophets are listed in the order of the Septuagint for the first six.

Chapter 2

1 This is what the Lord says: "I led this people out of bondage, and gave them commands by my servants the prophets; they refused to hear them and set my counsels at nothing. 2 The mother who bore them[a] says to them, 'Go, my children, for I am a widow and forsaken. 3 I brought you up with gladness, and I have lost you with mourning and sorrow, because you have sinned before the Lord your God and done what is evil in his sight. 4 But now what can I do for you? I am a widow and forsaken. Go, my children, and ask the Lord for mercy.' 5 But you, father,[b] I summon to bear witness, along with the children's mother, that they refused to keep my covenant, 6 that you may bring confusion upon them, and give their mother up to plunder, so that they may have no offspring. 7 Scatter their names among the nations;

wipe them out from the earth, for they have treated my sacred pledge with contempt.[c]
8 "Woe to you, Assyria,[d] who hide the unrighteous in your midst! Wicked nation, remember what I did to Sodom and Gomorrah, 9 whose land lies in lumps of pitch and heaps of ashes. So I will make those who have not listened to me, says the Lord Almighty."
10 This is what the Lord says to Ezra: "Announce to my people that the kingdom of Jerusalem, which I meant for Israel, I will give to them. 11 Their glory I will take for myself, and to these I will give the everlasting tents I had made ready for the others. 12 They will have the tree of life for fragrant perfume, and they will neither toil nor grow weary. 13 Go, and you will receive; pray that the days may be few for you, that they may be shortened.[e] The kingdom is already prepared for you; watch! 14 Call heaven and earth to witness; for I have broken evil in pieces and created good, for I live, says the Lord.
15 "Mother, embrace your children; bring them up with gladness. Make their feet firm like a dove's, for I have chosen you, says the Lord. 16 And I will raise the dead from their places, and bring them out of their tombs, for I have recognized my name in them.[f] 17 Do not be afraid, mother of the children, for I have chosen you, says the Lord. 18 To help you I will send my servants Isaiah and Jeremiah. By their counsel I have hallowed and made ready for you twelve trees heavy with fruits of many kinds, 19 as well as many springs flowing with milk and honey, and seven mighty mountains covered with roses and lilies;[g] with these I will fill your children with joy. 20 Do justice for the widow, secure justice for the ward, give to the needy, protect the orphan, clothe the naked, 21 care for the broken and the weak, do not mock the lame, protect the maimed, and let the blind come into the sight of my splendor. 22 Guard the old and the young within your walls. 23 Wherever you find the dead, sign them and commit them to the tomb,[h] and I will give you the first seat in my resurrection. 24 Stop, my people, and take your rest, for your rest is on its way. 25 Good nurse, nourish your children; make their feet firm. 26 As for the servants whom I have given you, not one of them shall perish, for I will require them from among your number. 27 Do not be weary; for

when the day of distress and anguish comes, others will weep and be sorrowful, but you will be cheerful and have plenty. 28 The nations will envy you, but they will be able to do nothing against you, says the Lord. 29 My hands will cover you, so that your children may not see Gehenna.[i] 30 Rejoice, mother, with your children, for I will deliver you, says the Lord. 31 Remember your children who are asleep, because I will lead them out of the hidden places of the earth[j] and show them mercy; for I am merciful, says the Lord Almighty. 32 Embrace your children until I come, and proclaim mercy to them;[k] for my springs overflow, and my grace will not fail."

33 I, Ezra, was given a command by the Lord on Mount Horeb[l] to go to Israel; but when I reached them, they turned me away and rejected the Lord's commandment. 34 So I tell you, nations that listen and understand: "Wait for your shepherd; he will give you eternal rest, because the one who will come at the end of the age is near. 35 Be ready for the rewards of the kingdom, for everlasting light will shine upon you for evermore. 36 Escape from the shadow of this world, and take hold of the delight of your glory. I openly bear witness to my Savior.[m] 37 Receive what has been entrusted to you and be glad, giving thanks to him who has called you to the heavenly kingdoms. 38 Get up and stand, and look at the number of those who have received the seal[n] at the Lord's feast. 39 They who have passed over out of the world's shadow have been given shining robes by the Lord. 40 Take back your full number, Zion, and close the roll of those who belong to you and are dressed in white,[o] who have kept the law of the Lord. 41 The number of your children whom you desired is full; implore the authority of the Lord that your people, who have been called from the beginning, may be made holy."

42 I, Ezra, saw upon Mount Zion a vast throng, more than I could count, and with songs they were all praising the Lord. 43 Among them stood a youth of lofty stature, higher than all the rest, who set crowns upon the head of each one, and he was lifted up all the more. And I was held fast in wonder. 44 Then I asked the angel, "Who are these, my lord?" 45 He replied, "These have laid aside the garment of mortality and taken on the garment of immortality, and they have confessed God's name.

Now they receive their crowns and their palms." [46] And I asked the angel, "And that youth who sets the crowns on them and gives the palms into their hands, who is he?" [47] He replied, "It is the Son of God, whom they confessed in this world." Then I began to extol those who had stood firm and brave for the Lord's name. [48] Then the angel said to me, "Go, tell my people what kind of wonders of the Lord God you have seen, and how great they are."

Notes

- a (2:2) The mother is Jerusalem or Zion (compare Baruch 4:9–23; Isaiah 54:1); later in the chapter (2:15–17) the mother is the church of the new people.
- b (2:5) Latin pater, "father," that is, Ezra, or perhaps God; the text is uncertain.
- c (2:7) Latin sacramentum, "sacred pledge," a word used of covenant and oath.
- d (2:8) The Latin has Assur, the old name of Assyria, here probably a symbol for Rome or for a hostile power; compare 15:28–33.
- e (2:13) Latin "ask for yourselves few days, that they may linger," an obscure phrase; the sense may be that the days before the end should be shortened (compare Matthew 24:22).
- f (2:16) Latin "for I have known my name in Israel"; the Clementine text, followed here, reads "in Israel," which seems contrary to the context; other manuscripts reportedly read differently.
- g (2:19) The twelve trees, springs of milk and honey, and seven mountains recall Revelation 22:2 and the paradise traditions of 1 Enoch 24–25; compare also 2 Esdras 2:12.
- h (2:23) Latin signans, "marking with a sign," perhaps the sign of the cross in burial; compare Tobit 1:17–18 on burying the dead.
- i (2:29) Gehenna, the Valley of Hinnom south of Jerusalem (Jeremiah 7:31–32), became a name for the place of fiery punishment of the wicked; compare 7:36.
- j (2:31) Latin "from the sides (or hidden recesses) of the earth."
- k (2:32) Latin "and that I may show them mercy."
- l (2:33) Horeb, another name for Mount Sinai (Exodus 3:1; Deuteronomy 5:2). The writer presents Ezra as a second Moses (compare 14:3–4).
- m (2:36) Latin "I testify openly to my Savior," a plainly Christian phrase; Ezra speaks as a herald of Christ.
- n (2:38) Compare Revelation 7:3–4, the sealing of the servants of God.
- o (2:40) Latin candidatos, "those clothed in white"; compare Revelation 3:4–5; 7:9, 13–14.

Chapter 3

[1] In the thirtieth year[a] after the ruin of the city[b] I was in Babylon. I lay troubled upon my bed, and my thoughts rose up over my heart,

2 for I had seen Zion forsaken, and the plenty of those who dwelt
in Babylon. 3 My spirit was sorely shaken, and I began to address
the Most High[c] with fearful words. 4 I said, "Lord and Master, at
the beginning, when you planted the earth, you spoke, you alone,
and gave command to the dust,[d] 5 and it yielded you Adam, a body
without life. Yet he too was something your hands had shaped; you
blew into him a spirit of life, and he came alive before you. 6 You
brought him into the garden your right hand had planted before ever
the earth came forth.[e] 7 To him you gave charge to love your way, but
he went beyond it; and at once you laid death upon him and upon
his generations. From him sprang nations and tribes, peoples and
kindreds beyond count. 8 Each nation went its own willful road; they
did outrageous things before you and scorned your precepts. 9 Again,
in due season, you sent a deluge over those who peopled the world,
and wiped them out. 10 And the same lot fell on each: as death fell to
Adam, so the deluge to these. 11 Yet one among them you spared, Noah[f]
and his house, and from him came all the just. 12 Then, when earth's
inhabitants began to increase and had multiplied sons and peoples
and many nations, they set about wickedness again, worse than the
first. 13 And while they were doing evil before you, you picked out
one man among them for yourself; Abraham[g] was his name. 14 Him
you loved, and to him only you disclosed your will. 15 You set up an
eternal covenant with him and told him you would never abandon
his seed. You granted him Isaac, and to Isaac you granted Jacob and
Esau. 16 Jacob you kept apart for yourself; Esau you put away. And
Jacob grew into a vast throng. 17 When you brought his seed up out
of Egypt, you led them to Mount Sinai. 18 You bowed the heavens and
shook[h] the earth; you moved the globe and set the abysses trembling
and threw the world into confusion. 19 Through four gates your glory
went, fire and earthquake, wind and frost,[i] that you might give a law
to Jacob's seed, and diligent teaching to the line of Israel. 20 Still you
did not remove the wicked heart from them, so that your law could
yield its fruit in them. 21 For the first Adam, carrying a wicked heart,
broke your command and was overpowered, and so too all born from
him. 22 So the weakness stayed on; the law was in the people's heart,

but with the root's malice in it,[j] and the good went away while the wicked remained. 23 Times went by, the years ran out, and you raised up a servant for yourself called David. 24 You bade him build a city to your name and offer you frankincense and offerings in it. 25 For many years this was so. Then the city's people fell into sin, 26 in all things acting just as Adam and all his generations acted, for they too bore the wicked heart. 27 So you handed your city over into your enemies' hands.

28 "Then I said in my heart, 'Do Babylon's people act any better? Is that why she lords it over Zion?'[k] 29 For when I arrived here I beheld ungodliness past counting; these thirty years my soul has looked on a multitude of wrongdoers, and my heart sank within me. 30 I saw how you put up with their sinning, how you spare the godless, while your own people you have destroyed and your foes you have kept safe; and you have not made known[l] 31 to anyone how your way is to be grasped.[m] Is Babylon's conduct better than Zion's? 32 Has some other nation known you, apart from Israel? Or which tribes have trusted your covenants as Jacob has? 33 Yet no wage of theirs has come to light, and their toil has yielded nothing. I have traveled widely among the nations and seen them thriving, and they give no thought to your commands. 34 So now put our wrongs and the wrongs of the world's dwellers on the scales, and it will become plain which side the balance tips toward.[n] 35 When did the dwellers on earth ever fail to sin before you? What nation has observed your commands like this? 36 Men you may find, one by one and named, who have kept your commands; nations you will not find."

Notes

- a (3:1) Chapters 3–14 are the original Jewish apocalypse called 4 Ezra, written about AD 100 after the Roman destruction of Jerusalem (AD 70), in Hebrew or Aramaic; the original and the Greek translation are lost, and the book survives in Latin, Syriac, Ethiopic, and other versions. It consists of seven visions or episodes (3:1–5:20; 5:21–6:34; 6:35–9:25; 9:26–10:59; 11:1–12:51; 13:1–58; 14:1–48).
- b (3:1) The thirtieth year after the destruction of Jerusalem in 587/586 BC would be about 557 BC, a symbolic date that also points to about AD 100, thirty years after the Romans destroyed the city. The Clementine Latin begins here; other Latin manuscripts and the oriental versions reportedly begin, "I, Salathiel, who am

also called Ezra," identifying the seer with Shealtiel, the father of Zerubbabel (1 Chronicles 3:17; Ezra 3:2).

- c (3:3) Latin Altissimus, "the Most High," the commonest name for God in this book.
- d (3:4) Latin "you commanded the people," evidently a corruption; the sense required is "the dust," from which Adam was made, as the Syriac reportedly reads.
- e (3:6) Latin "before the earth came forward"; the garden was believed to have been created before the world (compare 6:2–6; Genesis 2:8, where the Hebrew miqqedem can mean "from of old").
- f (3:11) Noah means "rest."
- g (3:13) Abraham means "father of a multitude" (Genesis 17:5).
- h (3:18) Latin statuisti, "you set (the earth) fast"; the Syriac reportedly reads "shook," which suits the context.
- i (3:19) Compare Exodus 19:16–18 and Psalm 68:8. The "four gates" are perhaps four heavenly regions through which the glory of God passed to Sinai.
- j (3:22) Latin "with the malignity of the root"; the "evil heart" (Latin cor malignum) corresponds to the rabbinic notion of the evil inclination (yetzer ha-ra).
- k (3:28) Babylon is a cipher for Rome, as in Revelation 14:8 and 1 Peter 5:13.
- l (3:30) The Latin of verses 30–31 is broken; it reads literally "and you did not indicate. I do not remember at all how this way should be forsaken." The rendering follows the general sense.
- m (3:31) See the previous note.
- n (3:34) Latin "and your name will not be found except in Israel," which does not fit the sense; the rendering follows the reading reported in the oriental versions ("which way the scale inclines").

Chapter 4

1 The angel sent to me, named Uriel,[a] replied to me 2 and said, "In this world your heart has quite overreached itself. Do you mean to grasp the Most High's way?" 3 "Yes, my lord," I said. He replied, "Three ways I have been sent to show you, and three likenesses to put before you. 4 Explain one of these to me, and I in turn will point out the way you yearn to see and teach you the origin of the wicked heart." 5 "Speak on, my lord," I said. He said to me, "Go and weigh out for me the heaviness of fire; or take the measure for me of a gust of wind; or summon back for me a day already gone." 6 I replied, "What human born could do such things, that you put such questions to me?" 7 He said to me, "Suppose I had questioned you thus: 'How many dwellings lie in the sea's heart? How many springs at the head of the abyss? How many channels above the firmament? Where are the ways out

of paradise?' [8] You might perhaps have told me, 'Into the abyss I have not gone down, nor yet into the underworld,[b] and up to heaven I never climbed.' [9] But I have questioned you only on fire and wind and day, which you have lived through and cannot be parted from, and you have given me no reply concerning them." [10] Then he told me, "What is yours and has grown up along with you, you cannot know; [11] so how should your vessel[c] have room for the Most High's way? How can a man worn away by a decaying world understand what does not decay?"[d] Hearing this, I fell face down[e] [12] and told him, "Better for us never to have been than to come and live amid godlessness and suffer without knowing the reason."

[13] He replied, "Once I went out to a wood of trees on the plain, and they took counsel together. [14] 'Come,' they said, 'let us march and wage war on the sea, to drive it back before us and gain more woodland for ourselves.' [15] The sea's billows took counsel the same way: 'Come,' they said, 'let us go up and defeat the plain's woodland, and so there too win fresh country for ourselves.' [16] The wood's scheme was in vain; fire came and devoured it. [17] So too the billows' scheme; the sand rose against them and barred their way. [18] Had you been set to judge them, which would you have begun to acquit, and which to convict?" [19] I replied, "Both of them schemed foolishly. The dry ground has been allotted to the wood, and to the sea a place for carrying its billows." [20] He replied, "Your verdict is a good one. Then why not give the same verdict upon yourself? [21] As dry ground belongs to the wood and the sea to its billows, so earth's dwellers can grasp only what pertains to earth, and he who dwells above the heavens what lies at the heights of heaven."[f]

[22] I replied, "I beg you, lord, why[g] was the faculty of understanding granted me? [23] It was not about things on high that I meant to ask, but about what passes by us daily: why Israel has been made a laughingstock to the nations; why the people you loved has been surrendered to godless tribes; why our fathers' law has been wiped out, and the written covenants are nowhere to be found. [24] We go out of the world as locusts do; our life is bewilderment and dread,[h] and we do not deserve to receive mercy. [25] Then what will he do

for the sake of his name, called over us? Those are my questions."
26 He replied, "If you live, you will see; and if you search far, many
times you will wonder;[i] for the world is rushing quickly toward its
passing. 27 It cannot contain what is pledged to the just for the times
to come, since this world is crammed with wrong and weakness. 28 As
to what you ask: evil has indeed been sown, yet its overthrow is still
to come. 29 Unless, then, the sown crop is cut down, and the ground
where evil was planted vanishes, the place planted with good cannot
arrive. 30 A seed of wicked grain was planted in Adam's heart at the
start; what a crop of godlessness it has raised to this day, and will
raise until the threshing floor arrives! 31 Reckon up for yourself what
a yield of godlessness one seed of wicked grain has brought forth. 32
When ears beyond counting are reaped, what a vast threshing floor
will they make!"
33 I replied, "How, and when, will this happen? Why are our years
short and wretched?" 34 He replied, "Do not outrun the Most High.
Your eagerness is on your own account,[j] but the One on high hastens
for the sake of multitudes. 35 Did not the souls of the just, in their
storehouses, raise these very questions: 'For how long shall we wait
in this way?[k] When comes the fruit of the threshing floor, our wage?'
36 To them Jeremiel[l] the archangel made answer: 'When the full count
of ones such as you is reached;[m] for he has weighed the world on
scales, 37 the seasons he has measured with a measure and counted
with a count, and he will neither stir nor rouse them until the measure
foretold is filled.' " 38 I replied, "Lord and Master, yet all of us too are
brimming with godlessness. 39 Perhaps it is our doing that the just
are kept from their threshing floor, because of the sins of earth's
dwellers." 40 He replied, "Go, inquire of a woman with child, when she
has finished her ninth month, whether her womb is still able to hold
the infant back inside her." 41 "It is not able, lord," I said. He told me, "In
the underworld the souls' storehouses resemble a womb. 42 Just as one
giving birth presses on to be free of the pains of labor, so these press
on to give up what was committed to them. 43 Then what you long to
see will be disclosed to you from the start." 44 I replied, "If I have found
grace in your eyes, if it can be, and if I am worthy, 45 disclose this to

me: is more yet to come than what is over, or have greater things gone by than what lies ahead? [46] The past I know; what lies ahead I cannot tell." [47] He told me, "Take your stand on the right, and I will give you the interpretation of a likeness." [48] I stood and watched, and there before me a burning oven went past; when the blaze had gone, I watched, and look, smoke was left over. [49] Next a cloud brimming with water went past me and let loose a great downpour with force; and once the force of the rain was spent, raindrops were left in it. [50] He told me, "Think it over: as the rain exceeded the drops and the fire the smoke, so the measure already gone by far exceeded the rest. Yet the drops and the smoke were left." [51] Then I prayed: "Will I be alive, do you think, until that time? Or what will happen in that time?" [52] He replied, "About the signs you inquire of, I can tell you a portion. But about your own life I was not sent to speak to you; indeed I do not know.

Notes

- a (4:1) Uriel means "God is my light." In 1 Enoch 20:2 he is one of the archangels, set over the world and over Tartarus.
- b (4:8) Latin infernum, the world of the dead (Hebrew Sheol).
- c (4:11) That is, the mind, as the container of understanding (compare 2 Corinthians 4:7).
- d (4:11) Latin "understand the corruption evident in my face," an obscure phrase; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported ("the incorruptible").
- e (4:11) The words "When I heard this, I fell on my face" are not in the Clementine Latin; they are reportedly found in the Syriac and Ethiopic and are supplied here for the sense.
- f (4:21) Compare John 3:12, 31.
- g (4:22) Latin "that I may be given the sense of understanding," here with a question as in the oriental versions, as reported.
- h (4:24) Latin stupor et pavor, "astonishment and fear"; other witnesses reportedly read "a vapor," in line with James 4:14. The text is uncertain.
- i (4:26) Latin "If you search much, you will often marvel"; the rendering combines the Latin with the fuller reading reported in the oriental versions.
- j (4:34) Latin "For you hasten vainly to be above him, for your excess is great." The rendering follows the clearer sense reported in the oriental versions.
- k (4:35) Latin "How long do I hope thus?"

- l (4:36) Jeremiel (Hebrew perhaps Jerahmeel, "God has mercy," or Ramiel, "God is exalted") is named as an archangel set over the risen souls in 1 Enoch 20:8 (Remiel, in the Greek).
- m (4:36) Latin "When the number of seeds in you is completed." Compare Revelation 6:9–11, where the souls under the altar are told to wait until the number of their fellow servants is complete.

Chapter 5

1 "But as to the signs: look, days are coming when earth's dwellers will be seized with great dismay,[a] and the way of truth will be hidden away, and the land will be barren of faith. 2 Wrong will increase beyond what you now see yourself, and beyond what you heard of long ago. 3 And the country you now see ruling will be trackless, and men will see it laid waste.[b] 4 Should the Most High grant you life, you will see it after the third trumpet;[c] then all at once the sun will shine out again by night, and the moon three times by day. 5 Blood will drip out of wood, and stone will give forth its voice; peoples will be in an uproar, 6 and one will reign whom earth's dwellers do not expect,[d] and the birds will migrate away. 7 The Sea of Sodom[e] will cast up fish, and at night will utter a voice which many have not known, but all will hear its voice. 8 There will be chaos in many places, fire will break out again and again, the wild beasts will roam beyond their haunts, and women in their impurity will bring forth monsters. 9 Salt water will be found in the sweet, and friends one and all will attack one another. Then reason will hide itself, and understanding will withdraw into its storehouse, 10 and it will be sought by many and not be found; and wrong and lack of restraint will increase on earth. 11 One country will ask its neighbor, 'Has righteousness, the kind that makes men just, passed through you?' And it will say no. 12 In that season people will hope and not obtain; they will toil, and their ways will not prosper. 13 Such are the signs I am permitted to tell you. Should you pray again, and weep as now, and keep a fast of seven days, you will hear yet greater things than these."

14 At that I woke; a violent shudder ran through my body, and my soul labored until it nearly gave way. 15 But the angel who had come and spoken with me took hold of me, strengthened me, and stood me on

my feet. 16 On the second night Salathiel,[f] the leader of the people,
came and asked me, "Where have you been all this time? And why
is your face so sad? 17 Are you not aware that Israel has been put in
your charge in the country where they were carried away? 18 So get
up and eat a little bread, and do not desert us, like a shepherd who
leaves his flock to savage wolves." 19 I told him, "Leave me, and stay
away from me for seven days; after that you may come to me."[g] He
heard my words and went away. 20 So I fasted seven days, wailing and
weeping, as Uriel the angel had instructed me.
21 After seven days[h] the thoughts of my heart were again very grievous
to me, 22 and my soul took up once more the spirit of understanding,
and I began again to speak words before the Most High. 23 I said, "Lord
and Master, out of all the forest of the earth and all its trees you have
picked one vine; 24 out of all the lands of the world you have picked
for yourself one pit;[i] out of all the flowers of the world you have
picked for yourself one lily; 25 out of all the depths of the sea you have
filled for yourself one stream; out of all the cities ever built you have
set apart Zion for yourself; 26 out of all the birds that were created
you have named for yourself one dove; out of all the cattle that were
fashioned you have chosen[j] for yourself one sheep; 27 and out of all
the peoples that have multiplied you have gained for yourself one
people; and to this people whom you desired you have granted a law
approved above all. 28 And now, Lord, why have you handed over the
one to the many, and set others above the single root,[k] and scattered
your only one among many? 29 Those who opposed your promises
have trampled on them, those who put no faith in your covenants.
30 If you truly hate your people, they ought to be punished by your
own hands."
31 After I had said these things, the angel who had visited me the night
before was sent to me again, 32 and he said to me, "Listen to me, and I
will teach you; pay attention to me, and I will tell you more." 33 "Speak,
my lord," I said. And he said to me, "You are deeply distressed in mind
for Israel's sake. Do you love him more than the One who made him?"
34 I answered, "No, my lord, I spoke out of sorrow. Every hour my
heart[l] torments me as I try to understand the way of the Most High

and to investigate some part of his judgment." 35 He told me, "You cannot." And I said, "Why not, lord? Why then was I born? Or why did my mother's womb not become my grave, so that I would not have seen the travail of Jacob and the exhaustion of Israel's race?" 36 He told me, "Count up for me those who have not yet come; gather for me the scattered raindrops; make the withered flowers green again for me; 37 open for me the chambers that are shut, and bring out for me the winds locked up in them; or show me the picture of a voice. Then I will show you the travail you ask to see." 38 I said, "Lord and Master, who can know these things except one whose dwelling is not among mortals? 39 But I am without wisdom, so how can I speak about the things you have asked me?" 40 He told me, "Just as you cannot do one of the things I have named, so you will not be able to discover my judgment, or the love I have pledged to my people at the end."
41 I said, "But look, lord, you are near to those who are there at the end; what then will they do who were before me, or we ourselves, or those who come after us?" 42 He told me, "I will liken my judgment to a ring:[m] as there is no lagging for the last, so there is no hurrying for the first." 43 I replied, "Could you not have made those already made, and those now living, and those to come, all at once, so as to show your judgment the sooner?" 44 He replied, "The creature cannot go faster than the Creator, nor can the world hold all at once those who are to be created in it." 45 I said, "How then have you told your servant that you will surely give life all at once to the creation you have made?[n] If they are indeed to live all at once, and creation will hold them, then it could hold those now present all at once." 46 He told me, "Put a question to a woman's womb: 'If you give birth, why is it only in due time?' Ask it, then, to deliver ten at once." 47 I said, "Surely it cannot, but only each at its own time." 48 He told me, "I too have made the earth a womb for those sown upon it in their own times. 49 For just as an infant does not bring forth, nor she who has grown old any longer,[o] so I have ordered the world I created."
50 I questioned him further: "Since you have now opened the way to me, I will speak before you. Is our mother, of whom you told me, still young, or is she already nearing old age?"[p] 51 He replied, "Ask a

woman who bears children, and she will tell you. [52] Say to her, 'Why are those whom you bear now not like those you bore before, but smaller in stature?' [53] And she herself will answer you, 'Children born in the strength of youth are different from those born when old age has come and the womb is wearing out.' [54] So consider for yourself as well: you people are smaller in stature than those before you, [55] and those who come after you will be smaller than you, since they are born from a creation that is already growing old and has passed the strength of youth." [56] I said, "Lord, if I have won your favor, please show your servant who it is that you will send to visit your creation."[q]

Notes

- a (5:1) Latin in censu multo, "with a great census" (or "with great wealth"), apparently a corruption; the oriental versions reportedly read "with great terror."
- b (5:3) Latin "and the region you now see ruling will be on a set-down footprint," an obscure phrase; the rendering follows the sense reported in the oriental versions ("a trackless waste"). The ruling country is Rome.
- c (5:4) Latin tubam, "trumpet"; the Clementine text supplies the noun, which some manuscripts reportedly lack. The oriental versions reportedly read "after the third period" or "after the third day," and some add that the land will be thrown into confusion.
- d (5:6) Perhaps a reference to an unexpected ruler, or to the antichrist; the identification is uncertain.
- e (5:7) The Dead Sea.
- f (5:16) Latin Salathiel; other witnesses reportedly read Phaltiel (Hebrew Paltiel, "God is my deliverance"). Here the name belongs to a leader of the people, not to Ezra himself (compare 3:1 note).
- g (5:19) The words "for seven days, and then you may come to me" are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported; the Latin ends with "do not come near me."
- h (5:21) The second vision runs from 5:21 to 6:34.
- i (5:24) Latin foveam, "pit" or "hollow"; the oriental versions reportedly read "region" or "land."
- j (5:26) Latin providisti, "foreseen" or "provided."
- k (5:28) Latin "and prepared others upon the one root."
- l (5:34) Latin renes, "kidneys," regarded as the seat of the emotions.
- m (5:42) Latin coronae, "to a crown" or "wreath," that is, a circle in which there is neither first nor last.
- n (5:45) That is, at the resurrection. The Latin of the verse is obscure; the rendering follows the general sense.
- o (5:49) Latin "as an infant does not bear what belongs to the old"; the rendering follows the fuller sense reported in the oriental versions.

- p (5:50) “Our mother” is the earth (compare 10:9 and Sirach 40:1).
- q (5:56) In the Clementine Latin, verses 55 and 56 form a single verse (5:55), so that the chapter has 55 verses; the numbering of most English versions is followed here.

Chapter 6

1 He told me, “At the start of the earthly globe, before the world’s gateways stood in place, before the gathered winds blew, 2 before the peals of thunder sounded, before the lightning flashes shone, before the foundations of paradise were laid, 3 before its lovely flowers were seen, before the powers that move were made firm,[a] before the countless hosts of angels were assembled, 4 before the heights of the air were lifted up, before the measures of the firmaments were named, before the furnaces in Zion were glowing hot,[b] 5 before the present years were searched out, before the schemes of those who now sin were estranged,[c] and before those who have stored up faith as treasure were sealed: 6 then I thought these things out, and they came into being through me alone and through no other; and the end shall come through me, and through no other.”

7 I replied, “What will divide the ages? Or when will the end of the first be, and the beginning of the one that follows?” 8 He told me, “From Abraham to Isaac:[d] when Jacob and Esau were born to him, Jacob’s hand gripped Esau’s heel from the start. 9 For Esau is the end of this world, and Jacob the beginning of the world that follows. 10 The hand of a man lies between heel and hand.[e] Seek nothing further, Ezra.”

11 I replied, “Lord and Master, if I have found grace in your eyes, 12 I pray you, show your servant the end of your signs, part of which you showed me on the night before.” 13 He replied, “Rise and stand on your feet, and you will hear a voice of the fullest sound. 14 There will be something like a shaking, yet the place on which you stand will not be shaken. 15 So when it speaks, do not take fright; for the word concerns the end, and the foundation of the earth understands. 16 It trembles and quakes at that speech, since it knows that at their end these things must be transformed.”

17 When I had heard this, I rose to my feet and listened, and there was a voice speaking, whose sound was like the roar of many waters. 18 It said, “Look, days are coming, and the time will be when I begin to

draw near to visit the dwellers on the earth, 19 and when I begin to call
to account those who have done harm unjustly by their wrongdoing,
and when the humiliation of Zion is complete, 20 and when the seal
is set upon the world that is about to pass away, then I will perform
these signs: books will be opened before the face of the firmament,
and all will see together. 21 Babies a year old will speak with their
voices; women with child will give birth to infants before their time,
at three and four months, and these will live and leap about.[f] 22
Sown fields will suddenly be found unsown, and full storehouses will
suddenly be found empty. 23 A trumpet will sound aloud, and when all
hear it, they will suddenly be terrified. 24 At that season friends will
make war on friends as though they were enemies, the earth and its
dwellers will be terrified, and the springs of the fountains will stand
still and not run for three hours.[g] 25 And whoever is left of all those
of whom I have told you will be saved and will see my salvation and
the end of your world. 26 They will see those who were taken up,[h]
people who have not tasted death since their birth. And the heart of
earth's dwellers will be changed and turned to another mind. 27 For
evil will be blotted out and deceit put out like a flame; 28 faith will
flower, corruption will be overcome, and truth will be made plain,
which for so many days has been without fruit."
29 While he was speaking to me, I gradually[i] gazed upon the one before
whom I stood, 30 and he said these things to me: "I have come to show
you the time of the night that is coming.[j] 31 If you pray once more,
and fast again for seven days, I will once more tell you things greater
than these, by day.[k] 32 For your voice has been heard before the Most
High; the Mighty One has seen your upright conduct, and has taken
note of the purity you have kept since your youth. 33 That is why he
sent me to show you all this, and to tell you: Take heart, and do not
fear, 34 and do not be quick to ponder vain things about the former
times, so that you may not be hasty in the last times."
35 After this I wept once more and fasted seven days in the same way,
to complete the three weeks[l] I had been told of. 36 On the eighth night[m]
my heart was disturbed again, and I began to speak in front of the
Most High. 37 For my spirit was all aflame, and my soul was in anguish.

38 I said, "Lord, you spoke at the beginning of creation, on the first
day, saying, 'Let heaven and earth be made,' and your word was a
finished work. 39 And then spirit was there, and darkness and silence
hovered round about; the sound of the human voice was not yet from
you.[n] 40 Then you commanded a shining light to be brought out of
your storehouses, so that your work might be seen. 41 On the second
day you made the spirit of the firmament and told it to separate
the waters, so that one part would move upward and the other stay
below. 42 On day three you bade the waters gather into one-seventh
of the earth; the other six parts you made dry and preserved, so that
out of them there might be things sown by God and tilled, to serve
before you.[o] 43 Your word went out, and straightway the deed was
accomplished. 44 Suddenly there came forth fruit in boundless abun-
dance, pleasures of taste of every kind, flowers of unfading color, and
scents of fragrance past finding out. These were made on the third
day. 45 On day four you bade the sun's splendor, the moon's light, and
the array of stars come to be, 46 and you commanded them to serve
humankind, which was about to be formed. 47 On the fifth day you
told the seventh part, where the water had been gathered, to bring
forth living creatures, birds and fish; and so it came to be. 48 The dumb
and lifeless water produced living creatures at God's bidding, so that
from this the nations might tell of your wonders. 49 Then you kept two
living creatures; the name of one you called Enoch,[p] and the name of
the other Leviathan.[q] 50 You separated them from one another, for the
seventh part, where the water had been gathered, could not contain
them both. 51 To Enoch you allotted one portion, dried out on day
three, as his dwelling, where a thousand mountains stand;[r] 52 but to
Leviathan you gave the seventh part, the watery one. You have kept
them to be food[s] for whom you will, and when you will. 53 On day six
you bade the earth produce before you beasts of burden and of the
field, and things that creep; 54 and over these Adam, whom you made
ruler over all the works you had made; and from him we all come,
the people you have chosen.
55 "All this I have told before you, Lord, because you have said that it
was for our sake that you created the world.[t] 56 As for the other nations

which have come from Adam, you have said that they are nothing, that they are like spittle, and you have likened their abundance to a drip from a jar.[u] 57 And now, Lord, look: these nations, which are reckoned as nothing, have begun to lord it over us and to devour us. 58 But we your people, whom you have called your firstborn, only begotten, your zealous one[v] and dearly loved, have been handed over into their hands. 59 If the world was made on our account, why is our world not ours to inherit? How much longer must this go on?"

Notes

- a (6:3) Latin motae virtutes, "the moving powers," perhaps the heavenly bodies or the forces of nature.
- b (6:4) That is, before the altar fires of the temple were kindled, or perhaps the fires of judgment (compare Isaiah 31:9).
- c (6:5) Latin abalienarentur, "were alienated," that is, set apart or banished; the oriental versions reportedly read "were rejected."
- d (6:8) Latin "From Abraham to Isaac"; the oriental versions reportedly read "From Abraham to Abraham," that is, the dividing line runs through Abraham's own descendants. Compare Genesis 25:26.
- e (6:10) The Latin is obscure, reading literally "The hand of a man between the heel and the hand." The meaning is apparently that no interval separates this age from the next, as Jacob's hand held Esau's heel. Other witnesses reportedly read, "For the heel of a man and the hand: between them seek nothing else."
- f (6:21) Latin et suscitabuntur, "and they will be raised up." The rendering "leap about" follows the oriental versions, as reported.
- g (6:24) Ancient clocks reckoned hours from sunrise; three hours here is simply a short span of time, not a fixed clock time.
- h (6:26) Those taken up to heaven alive, such as Enoch (Genesis 5:24) and Elijah (2 Kings 2:11); compare 14:9.
- i (6:29) Latin paulatim, "little by little." The oriental versions reportedly read "he looked at me," and the Latin may be corrupt.
- j (6:30) The meaning of this verse is uncertain; the Latin reads literally, "I have come to show you the time of the coming night."
- k (6:31) Latin "greater things than these by day than I have heard," apparently corrupt.
- l (6:35) The three weeks are the three periods of seven days' fasting (5:13, 20; 6:31, 35).
- m (6:36) The third vision begins here and runs to 9:25.
- n (6:39) The meaning is that at the beginning there was as yet no voice of any human being.

- o (6:42) Latin culta, “cultivated”; the Latin is obscure, and the rendering follows the general sense.
- p (6:49) Latin Henoch; elsewhere, as reported, the oriental versions read Behemoth, as in Job 40:15 (Hebrew behemoth, “beasts,” a great land monster). Enoch is apparently a corruption in the Latin tradition.
- q (6:49) Leviathan (Hebrew, perhaps “twisting one”) is the great sea monster of Job 41:1 and Isaiah 27:1. Compare 1 Enoch 60:7–9 and 2 Baruch 29:4.
- r (6:51) Compare Psalm 50:10, where the Hebrew of “cattle on a thousand hills” uses behemoth.
- s (6:52) Latin devorationem, “devouring”; in Jewish tradition Behemoth and Leviathan were to be food for the righteous in the messianic age (2 Baruch 29:4).
- t (6:55) Compare 7:11; 8:44; 9:13; and 2 Baruch 14:18–19; 15:7.
- u (6:56) Compare Isaiah 40:15, where the nations are like a drop from a bucket.
- v (6:58) Latin aemulatorem tuum, literally “your rival” or “one zealous for you”; the rendering “zealous one” follows the general sense. The words “and dearly loved” are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported.

Chapter 7

1 After I had ended this speech, there was sent to me the angel who
had been sent on the earlier nights. 2 He told me, “Get up, Ezra, and
listen to what I have come to say to you.” 3 “Speak, my God,”[a] I said.
And he told me, “There is a sea set in a broad expanse, so that it is
deep and vast; 4 but the way into it lies in a narrow place, so that it
is like a river. 5 If someone has a mind to enter the sea, to look upon
it or to be master of it, how can he reach its breadth unless he first
passes through the narrows? 6 Here is another: a city stands built on
level ground, and it is filled with every good thing. 7 But the way into
it is narrow and set on a steep slope, with fire on the right hand and
deep water on the left. 8 There is just one path set between them,
that is, between the fire and the water, and the path has room for no
more than a single footstep. 9 Suppose the city is granted to a man
to inherit; if he never gets past the peril placed before him, how will
his inheritance come to him?” 10 “That is so, lord,” I said. He told me,
“So also is Israel’s portion. 11 It was for their sake that I made the
world; and when Adam broke my statutes, what had been made was
judged. 12 And so the ways into this world became narrow, grievous,
and toilsome; few and evil, full of perils, and burdened with great
hardship. 13 But the ways into the greater world are broad and safe,

and they yield the fruit of immortality. 14 If, then, the living do not enter by these narrow and empty things, they cannot receive what has been laid up for them. 15 So now, why are you disturbed, since you are perishable? And why are you moved, since you are mortal? 16 And why have you not taken to heart what is to come, rather than what is present?"

17 I answered, "Lord and Master, your law establishes that the righteous will inherit these things and the ungodly will perish. 18 The righteous, then, will endure the narrow things in hope of the broad; but those who have lived ungodly lives will have suffered the narrow things and yet will not see the broad." 19 He told me, "There is no judge above God, and none who understands above the Most High. 20 For many now living are perishing, because the law of God that was set before them is disregarded. 21 For God gave strict orders to those who entered the world, telling them as they came what to do to live and what to keep in order to avoid punishment. 22 But they were not persuaded; they spoke against him and devised for themselves empty thoughts; 23 they set before themselves the snares of sin, and declared to the Most High that he does not exist, and they did not acknowledge his ways. 24 His law they scorned and his promises they denied; in his statutes they put no faith, and his works they did not perform. 25 Therefore, Ezra, the empty receive emptiness, and the full receive fullness.

26 "For see, the time will come when the signs I have foretold to you will come to pass; the bride[b] will appear, the city appearing,[c] and the land now hidden will be shown. 27 And everyone who has been set free from the evils I have foretold will see my wonders. 28 For my son Jesus[d] will be revealed with those who are with him, and those who are left will rejoice four hundred years.[e] 29 After those years my son the Christ[f] will die, and all who have human breath. 30 And the world will be turned back into the ancient silence for seven days, as at the earliest judgments,[g] so that none is left. 31 After seven days the age that is not yet awake will be roused, and what is perishable will die. 32 The earth will return those who are asleep in it, and the dust will release those who rest there in silence; and the storehouses

will give back the souls that were placed in their care. 33 The Most
High will be revealed upon the judgment seat, and miseries will pass
away, and long-suffering will be withdrawn.[h] 34 Only judgment will
remain; truth will stand, and faithfulness will grow strong. 35 Deeds
will follow, and the reward will be shown; righteous acts will awake,
and unrighteous acts will no longer rule.[i] 36 Then the pit[j] of torment
will appear, and opposite it the place of rest; the furnace of Gehenna[k]
will be displayed, and opposite it the paradise of delight. 37 Then the
Most High will address the nations that have been raised: 'Look and
understand whom you have denied, whom you have refused to serve,
and whose commandments you have despised. 38 Look to one side,
then the other: on this side are joy and rest, on that side fire and
torment.' That is what he will tell them on the day of judgment.[l] 39
This is the kind of day that has no sun, no moon, no stars, 40 no cloud,
no thunder, no lightning, no wind, no water, no air, no darkness, no
evening, no morning, 41 no summer, no spring, no heat, no winter, no
ice, no cold, no hail, no rain, no dew, 42 no noon, no night, no time
before dawn, no gleam, no brightness, no light, but only the splendor
of the glory of the Most High, by which all will begin to see what has
been set before them. 43 For it will last as long as a week of years.[m] 44
This is my judgment and its ordinance; but to you alone have I shown
these things."
45 Then I replied, "Lord, I said it then and I say it now: Happy are those
now living who keep what you have ordained! 46 But what of those for
whom I was praying? Which of those now alive has never sinned? Or
which of those ever born has not transgressed your covenant? 47 And
now I see that the world to come will bring joy to a few, but torment
to many. 48 For an evil heart has grown up in us, which has estranged
us from these things and brought us into corruption and the paths of
death; it has shown us the ways of destruction and set us far off from
life; and this not just a few, but nearly all who have been created."
49 He replied, "Listen to me, and I will instruct you, and I will correct
you once more.[n] 50 For this cause the Most High made two worlds, and
not one. 51 For since you have said that the righteous are not many
but few, and the ungodly abound, hear the answer to this. 52 If you

have a very few choice stones, will you set them alongside lead and clay according to their number?[o] 53 I said, "Lord, how could that be?" 54 He went on, "More than that, ask the earth, and she will tell you; coax her, and she will explain it to you. 55 Say to her, 'You produce gold and silver and copper, and also iron and lead and clay; 56 but silver is more plentiful than gold, and copper than silver, and iron than copper, lead than iron, and clay than lead.' 57 So judge for yourself which things are precious and to be desired: what is plentiful, or what is produced rarely?" 58 I said, "Lord and Master, what is plentiful is of less worth, for what is rarer is more precious." 59 He replied, "Weigh within yourself what you have thought: whoever has what is hard to get rejoices more than one who has plenty. 60 The same holds for the creation I have promised;[p] I will take joy in the few who will be saved, since they are the ones who have made my glory prevail now, and through them my name has now been named. 61 I will not grieve over the multitude of those who perish; for they are the ones likened to vapor, made equal to flame and smoke: they caught fire, blazed up, and were quenched."

62 I replied, "Earth, what is it you have given birth to, if understanding is fashioned from dust as are all other creatures? 63 Better had the dust itself never been born, so that the mind might not have come from it. 64 But as it is, the mind grows up with us, and that is why we are tormented: because we perish knowingly. 65 Let the human race mourn, and the wild beasts of the field be glad; let all who are born lament, but let the four-footed creatures and the cattle rejoice. 66 For it is far better with them than with us; they do not look for judgment, nor do they know of torments or of a salvation promised them after death. 67 What good is it to us that we shall be kept alive, if we are to be tormented with torment? 68 For all who are born are entangled in iniquities, full of sins and weighed down with offenses. 69 If after death we were not to come into judgment, it might perhaps have gone better with us."

70 He replied, "When the Most High was making the world, and Adam and all who came after him, he first prepared the judgment and what belongs to the judgment. 71 Now learn from your own words, for you

said that the mind grows up with us. [72] Those who abide on the earth will be tormented for this reason: that having understanding they did wickedness, and receiving the commandments they did not keep them, and having obtained the law they dealt falsely with what they received. [73] What then will they have to say at the judgment, or how will they answer in the last times? [74] For how long a time has the Most High shown patience toward those who inhabit the world, and not for their sake, but for the sake of the times he has foreordained!"
[75] I replied, "If I have found grace before you, lord, show your servant this as well: after death, when each of us yields up his soul, shall we be kept at rest until those times come when you will begin to make the creation new, or are we tormented at once?" [76] He replied, "This too I will show you. But do not mix yourself with those who have shown scorn, and do not count yourself among those who are tormented. [77] A treasury of deeds is laid up for you in the Most High's keeping, yet it will be hidden from your sight until the final times. [78] Now concerning death, the teaching is this: when the final sentence has gone forth from the Most High that a man shall die, as the spirit departs from the body to return again to him who gave it, it first worships the glory of the Most High. [79] And if the spirit belongs to the scornful, who did not walk in the Most High's way, who held his law in contempt and loathed the God-fearing, [80] such spirits will not enter into dwellings, but will wander about from then on in torments, always grieving and sorrowful, in seven ways.[q] [81] First way: they held the Most High's law in contempt. [82] The second way: because they can no longer make a good return, so as to live. [83] The third way is that they see the reward kept for those who have trusted the covenants of the Most High. [84] The fourth way: they consider the torment stored up for themselves in the last days. [85] The fifth way: they see the dwelling places of the others guarded by angels in deep silence. [86] The sixth way: they see how some of them[r] will presently pass over into torment. [87] The seventh way, which is greater than all those already listed, is that they will waste away in shame, be consumed with disgrace,[s] and wither with fear as they see the glory of the Most High, whom they sinned against in life and before whom they will be judged at the end of time.

88 “As for those who have kept the ways of the Most High, this is their
order, when they are about to be parted from the perishable vessel. 89
During the time they lived in it, they served the Most High with toil
and endured danger every hour, so as to keep the law of the Lawgiver
perfectly. 90 Therefore this is the teaching concerning them: 91 First
of all, they see with great exultation the glory of him who receives
them; for they will rest in seven orders. 92 The first order: because they
have striven with great toil to overcome the evil thought that was
formed along with them, so that it should not lead them astray from
life into death. 93 The second order: because they see the confusion
in which the souls of the ungodly wander, and the punishment that
awaits them. 94 The third order: they see the witness borne to them
by him who formed them, that while they lived they kept the law
entrusted to them in faith.[t] 95 The fourth order: they understand the
rest which they now enjoy, gathered in their storehouses in deep
silence, guarded by angels, and the glory that awaits them in the last
days. 96 The fifth order: they exult because they have fled now from
the perishable, and the world to come is theirs to inherit; beyond that,
they behold the cramped and toilsome place from which they were
freed, and the spacious one, which they are about to take up with
enjoyment, deathless. 97 The sixth order: they are shown that their
faces will shine like the sun and that they will become like the stars,
no longer subject to decay from then on. 98 The seventh order, which
surpasses all already named: they will exult boldly, be confident and
not ashamed, and be glad and unafraid; for they hurry to look upon
the face of the One they served while alive, from whose hand they
are to take their wages in glory. 99 This is the order of the souls of
the righteous, as is now announced; and the ways of torment already
described are what those who have been heedless will suffer from
now on.”

100 I replied, “Is time to be allowed, then, for the souls, once parted
from their bodies, to look upon the things you have told me of?” 101
He said, “Their freedom will last seven days, so that they may see
the things you have been told; after that they will be gathered into
their dwellings.”

102 I answered, “If I have won your favor, show your servant this as
well: on the day of judgment, will the righteous be able to plead
for the ungodly or to intercede for them before the Most High, 103
fathers for sons, or sons for parents, brothers for brothers, kin for
their nearest, or friends for those most dear to them.” 104 He answered,
“Since you have won my favor, I will show you this too. The day of
judgment is a day of decision,[u] and it will show everyone the seal of
truth. Just as today a father cannot send his son, or a son his father, or
a master his slave, or a friend his closest friend, to be sick, to sleep, to
eat, or to be healed in his place, 105 so no one will ever ask for mercy for
another on that day; for then each will bear his own unrighteousness
or righteousness.”[v]
106 I replied,[w] “How is it, then, that we find Abraham first praying
for the people of Sodom, and Moses for our ancestors who sinned
in the wilderness, 107 and he who came after Moses[x] for Israel in the
days of Achan,[y] 108 and Samuel[z] in the days of Saul, and David for
the destruction,[aa] and Solomon for those who would come to the
sanctuary, 109 and Elijah for those who received rain, and for one who
was dead, that he might live, 110 and Hezekiah for the people in the
days of Sennacherib, and many for many? 111 If, then, now that the
perishable has grown great and wrong has multiplied, the just made
petition for the godless, why should that not happen then too?” 112
He replied, “This present world is not the end, and glory does not
abide in it permanently;[ab] therefore those who were strong prayed
for the weak. 113 But the day of judgment will bring this age to an
end and begin the coming age of immortality, when decay will be
gone, 114 excess has been abolished, unbelief has been cut off, while
righteousness has grown and truth has sprung up. 115 Then no one will
be able to save one who has perished, nor to overwhelm one who has
conquered.”
116 I replied, “This is my first word and my last: it would have been
better not to give Adam the earth, or else, once it had been given, to
restrain him from sinning. 117 For what good is it to people to live in
sorrow now and to look for punishment after death? 118 Adam, what is
this you have done? The sin was yours, yet the downfall came not on

you only but on us as well, your offspring. 119 What good is it to us that
an immortal age has been promised to us, if we have done deeds that
bring death? 120 Or that an everlasting hope has been foretold to us, if
we have become utterly worthless and vain? 121 Or that dwellings of
health and safety are stored up for us, if we have lived wickedly? 122
Or that the glory of the Most High is stored up to shelter those who
have lived chaste lives,[ac] if we have walked in the worst of ways? 123
Or that a paradise will be shown, whose fruit remains unspoiled, in
which are security and healing, 124 if we are not to go in, since the
places where we have lived were unlovely?[ad] 125 Or that the faces of
those who practiced self-restraint will shine brighter than the stars, if
our faces will be blacker than darkness? 126 For while we lived and did
wrong, we did not consider that we would begin to suffer after death."
127 He replied, "This is the meaning of the contest which every person
born on the earth must wage: 128 if he loses, he must undergo what you
have described; but if he wins, what I describe will be his. 129 For this
is the way of which Moses spoke to the people while he was alive,
saying, 'Choose life for yourself, that you may live.'[ae] 130 But they did
not believe him, nor the prophets after him, nor even me, who have
spoken to them. 131 And so there will be no grief over their perdition
so great as the joy over those to whom salvation is assured."[af]
132 I answered, "I know, Lord, that the Most High is called merciful,
because he is merciful to those who have not yet entered the world; 133
and compassionate, because he shows compassion to those who turn
back to his law; 134 and long-suffering, because he shows forbearance
to those who have sinned, since they are his own works; 135 and
bountiful, because he is willing to give rather than to exact;[ag] 136 and
abounding in mercy, because he multiplies his mercies more and
more to those now living, to those who are gone, and to those yet
to come; 137 for if he did not multiply his mercies, the world would
not continue with those who inhabit it; 138 and he grants pardon, for
if he did not grant it out of his goodness, so that those who have
done wickedness might be relieved of their wickedness, not one ten-
thousandth of humankind could be kept alive; 139 and he is judge, for
if he did not forgive those who were created by his word, and blot out

the multitude of their offenses,[ah] [140] perhaps very few would be left of a countless multitude."

Notes

- a (7:3) Latin Deus meus, "my God"; the oriental versions reportedly read "my lord," as elsewhere in the book.
- b (7:26) The bride is the heavenly Jerusalem (compare 10:25–27; Revelation 21:2). The words "the bride will appear" follow the Clementine Latin, which here is apparently corrupt; the oriental versions reportedly read "the city that is now not seen will appear."
- c (7:26) See the previous note.
- d (7:28) The Latin reads "my son Jesus," evidently a Christian alteration; the Syriac reportedly reads "my son the Messiah," and other versions reportedly differ or omit the title. The original Jewish text spoke of the Messiah (Anointed One).
- e (7:28) The figure of four hundred years for the messianic kingdom is found only here; the Syriac reportedly reads thirty years, and other versions reportedly differ. Compare the thousand years of Revelation 20:4–6.
- f (7:29) Latin Christus, Greek for "Anointed One," that is, the Messiah. The death of the Messiah before the general resurrection is a distinctive feature of this book.
- g (7:30) Latin sicut in prioribus judiciis, "as in the former judgments"; the oriental versions reportedly read "as at the first beginnings," that is, as before creation (compare 6:39).
- h (7:33) Latin congregabitur, "will be gathered up," that is, brought to an end.
- i (7:35) Here the Clementine Latin, like the King James Version, passes directly from verse 35 to the verse numbered 106 in this translation (KJV 7:36). Verses 36–105 are the "missing fragment," preserved in the oriental versions but lost from nearly all Latin manuscripts, because a leaf had been cut out of the ninth-century Codex Sangermanensis, from which most later Latin copies descend. Robert L. Bensly recovered the Latin text from a ninth-century manuscript at Amiens (Codex Ambianensis) and published it in 1875 as The Missing Fragment of the Latin Translation of the Fourth Book of Ezra. The removal is often thought to have been deliberate, because verse 105 denies that anyone may pray for the ungodly on the day of judgment. The translation of verses 36–105 follows Bensly's Latin text.
- j (7:36) Latin lacus, "pit" or "lake"; compare Revelation 20:10, 14–15.
- k (7:36) Gehenna is the valley of Hinnom south of Jerusalem (Hebrew Ge Hinnom, "valley of Hinnom"), where children were once sacrificed (Jeremiah 7:31); the name came to mean the place of final punishment.
- l (7:38) Bensly's Latin reads "these things you will speak, saying to them on the day of judgment"; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- m (7:43) That is, seven years (compare Daniel 9:24–27). The oriental versions reportedly also read this.
- n (7:49) Latin de sequenti corripiam te, "I will correct you in what follows."

- o (7:52) Bensly's Latin reads "you will arrange them for yourself according to their number," apparently a corruption; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported. The meaning is that a few precious stones are not made worth less because they are few.
- p (7:60) Latin repromissa creatura, "the promised creation"; the oriental versions reportedly read "the judgment that I have promised."
- q (7:80) The words "in seven ways" are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported; the Latin lacks them here.
- r (7:86) Latin de eis, "of them," that is, of the ungodly spirits.
- s (7:87) Latin in honoribus, apparently a corruption (Bensly marks it as uncertain); the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- t (7:94) Latin per fidem, "through faith"; the phrase can also mean "in trust." Bensly discussed both senses.
- u (7:104) Latin dies decretorius, "the decisive day."
- v (7:105) Here the missing fragment ends; the next verse resumes the Clementine Latin at its 7:36.
- w (7:106) In the Clementine Latin and the King James Version this is 7:36, and the rest of the chapter is numbered 7:36–70 there (the KJV divides it into 35 verses, as here; the Clementine into 34). In this translation it is 7:106–140, following Bensly and most modern editions. Many readers will therefore find KJV 7:36 cited as 7:106.
- x (7:107) That is, Joshua (Joshua 7:6–9).
- y (7:107) Latin Achaz (Ahaz), apparently a corruption of Achan (Joshua 7:1–26); the oriental versions reportedly have Achan.
- z (7:108) The Clementine Latin reads "and Samuel," without "in the days of Saul," which is supplied from Bensly's text and the oriental versions as reported. Compare 1 Samuel 7:5–9; 12:19–23.
- aa (7:108) Latin confractione, "the breaking," that is, the plague (2 Samuel 24:15–25).
- ab (7:112) Latin "glory abides in it frequently," apparently corrupt; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- ac (7:122) Latin qui tarde conversati sunt, "those who lived slowly," apparently corrupt for "purely" or "chastely," as the oriental versions reportedly read.
- ad (7:124) Latin in ingratis locis, literally "in unpleasant places."
- ae (7:129) Deuteronomy 30:19.
- af (7:131) Latin "to whom salvation has been persuaded," that is, those who have been convinced of salvation.
- ag (7:135) Latin pro exigentiis, "according to demands"; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- ah (7:139) Latin "if he did not pardon those healed by his word and blot out the multitude of contentions."

Chapter 8

1 He replied, "For the many the Most High fashioned this world; for
the few, the one to come. 2 Let me set a likeness before you, Ezra. Put
your question to the earth, and she will tell you that she supplies a
great deal of soil from which clay pots are made, but only a little dust
from which gold comes. So it is with the course of this present world:
3 numerous are those created, but those saved are few."
4 I replied, "Then drink in understanding, my soul, and swallow down
wisdom![a] 5 For you have agreed to listen, and are eager to prophesy;[b]
yet no span has been granted you except only to live. 6 Lord, if you
do not allow your servant to pray before you, and give us seed for
the heart and tilling for the understanding, so that fruit may come of
it by which every mortal who bears the likeness of a human being
may live, 7 —for you alone exist, and we are the single handiwork
of your hands, as you have declared— 8 and just as the body is now
fashioned in the womb, and you furnish its members, your creature
is preserved in fire and water,[c] and for nine months the womb you
fashioned bears your creature that has been created within it. 9 But
both that which keeps and that which is kept will be kept,[d] and when
the time comes the womb gives back what has grown in it. 10 For
you have commanded that from the very members, that is, from the
breasts, milk be supplied to the fruit of the breasts, 11 so that what was
fashioned may be nourished for a time; and afterward you will guide
it in your mercy. 12 You reared it in your righteousness, instructed it
in your law, and corrected it by your understanding. 13 You will put
it to death as your creature, and bring it to life as your work. 14 If,
then, you destroy with a light command one who was fashioned with
such great labor, to what purpose was he made?[e] 15 And now I will
speak: about humankind as a whole you know best; but I will speak
about your people, for whose sake I am grieved, 16 and about your
inheritance, for whom I mourn, and about Israel, for whom I am sad,
and about Jacob, for whom I am in pain. 17 So I will begin by praying
to you for myself and for them, because I see the failings of those of
us who live on the earth; 18 but I have heard how swiftly the judgment

will come.[f] 19 So hear my voice and understand my speech, and I will
speak before you."
20 This is how Ezra's prayer begins, before he was taken up.[g] He said:
"Lord, you who live forever,[h] whose eyes look to the heights and the
sky, 21 whose throne is beyond estimating and whose glory is beyond
grasping, before whom the host of angels stands trembling, 22 whose
service takes the form of wind and fire,[i] whose word is true and whose
sayings endure, 23 whose command is mighty and whose ordinance is
terrible, whose look dries up the deeps and whose anger makes the
mountains melt away, and whose truth bears witness:[j] 24 give ear to
the prayer of your servant, and attend to the petition of your creature.
25 While I live I will speak, and while I have understanding I will
answer. 26 Do not regard the sins of your people, but those who serve
you faithfully. 27 Pay no heed to the godless pursuits of the nations,
but to those who have kept your testimonies through sufferings. 28 Do
not think of those who have lived deceitfully before you, but call to
mind those who have known your fear according to your will. 29 Do
not resolve to destroy those who have behaved like cattle, but look
upon those who have taught your law with splendor. 30 Do not be
indignant with those judged worse than beasts, but love those who
have always trusted in your righteousness and glory. 31 For we and
our fathers languish in such maladies; but because of us sinners you
will be called merciful. 32 For if you are pleased to show mercy to us,
who have no righteous deeds, then you will be called merciful. 33 For
the righteous, who have many works stored up with you, will receive
their reward from their own deeds. 34 But what is man, that you should
be angry with him? Or what is a perishable race, that you should be
so bitter toward it? 35 Truly, of all ever born there is none who has not
behaved godlessly, and of those who confess you[k] there is none who
has not gone astray. 36 For in this, Lord, your righteousness and your
goodness will be made known, when you show mercy to those who
have no store of good works."
37 He answered, "You have been right about some things, and it
will happen as you say. 38 For truly I will not concern myself with
the fashioning of those who have sinned, or with their death, their

judgment, or their destruction; 39 but I will rejoice over the creation
of the righteous, and remember also their pilgrimage, their salvation,
and the reward they will receive. 40 As I have spoken, therefore, so it
is. 41 For as the farmer sows many seeds on the ground and sets out
a multitude of plants, and yet not everything sown comes up safely
in due season, nor does everything planted take root, so too not all
those who have been sown in the world will be saved."
42 I replied, "If I have found grace, let me speak. 43 If the farmer's seed
does not sprout, or does not receive your rain in due season, or if it
is ruined by too much rain, it perishes.[l] 44 But man, who was formed
by your hands and is called your image because he is made like you,
and for whose sake you have formed all things, have you made him
like the farmer's seed?[m] 45 Do not be angry with us, but spare your
people and show mercy to your inheritance; for you are merciful to
your own creation."
46 He replied, "Things present are for those now present, and things
to come for those to come. 47 You are very far from being able to love
my creation as much as I do. But I have often drawn near to you
yourself, though never to the unrighteous.[n] 48 And in this also you are
admirable before the Most High, 49 in that you have humbled yourself,
as befits you, and have not counted yourself among the righteous
so as to be greatly glorified. 50 For many severe miseries will come
upon those who live in the world in the last times, because they have
lived in great pride. 51 But as for you, understand for yourself, and
seek out glory for those like you. 52 For it is for you that paradise has
been opened, the tree of life planted, the age to come made ready,
plenty provided, a city built, rest appointed,[o] goodness perfected, and
wisdom brought to completion. 53 The root of evil has been sealed up
from you; weakness and the moth[p] have been hidden from you, and
corruption has fled into the underworld to be forgotten. 54 Sorrows
have passed away, and at the end the treasure of immortality has been
made manifest. 55 So ask no more questions about the multitude of
those who perish. 56 For they too received freedom, but they scorned
the Most High, held his law in contempt, and forsook his ways. 57
Moreover, they have trampled on his righteous ones, 58 and have told

themselves in their hearts, ‘God does not exist,’ though they knew well they must die. [59] For just as the things foretold will welcome you, so thirst and torment, which have been prepared, will await them. For he did not wish anyone to be destroyed; [60] but those who were created have defiled the name of the one who made them, and have been ungrateful to the one who prepared life for them. [61] That is why my judgment is now drawing near. [62] These things I have not shown to all, but only to you and a few like you.”

[63] Then I replied,[q] “Look, lord, you have now shown me a host of signs which you will begin to perform in the last times, but you have not shown me at what time.”

Notes

- a (8:4) Latin “Swallow down, then, O soul, understanding, and devour what is wise.” Ezra addresses his own soul.
- b (8:5) Latin “For you have come together to obey, and wishing to prophesy”; the meaning is uncertain.
- c (8:8) The meaning of “fire and water” is uncertain; perhaps the warmth and fluid of the womb.
- d (8:9) The Latin of this verse is obscure.
- e (8:14) Latin “it is easy by your command to arrange that what was made be preserved”; the rendering follows the sense reported in the oriental versions.
- f (8:18) Latin “the swiftness of the judge who is to come.”
- g (8:20) The words are a heading within the text; many Latin manuscripts and the oriental versions reportedly have them. Ezra’s being “taken up” is described in 14:9, 49–50 (in the oriental versions; see 14:48 note).
- h (8:20) Latin “who inhabit the world (or the age)”; the oriental versions reportedly read “who abide for ever,” and the Latin may reflect a confusion of the two senses of Hebrew olam, “age, eternity, world.”
- i (8:22) Compare Psalm 104:4. The oriental versions reportedly read, “at whose command they are changed to wind and fire.”
- j (8:23) Latin “and truth bears witness”; the oriental versions reportedly read, “whose truth endures for ever.”
- k (8:35) That is, the faithful who confess God.
- l (8:43) The Latin of verse 43 lacks a main verb; the words “it perishes” are taken from the first word of verse 44 (sic periit, “so it perishes”).
- m (8:44) The Latin is confused; the rendering follows the sense reported in the oriental versions. Compare Genesis 1:26–27.

- n (8:47) Latin "I have often drawn near to you and to yourself, but never to the unrighteous"; the oriental versions reportedly read, "you have often compared yourself to the unrighteous. Never do so!"
- o (8:52) Latin probata, "approved," perhaps "appointed."
- p (8:53) Latin tinea, "moth" or "worm," an image of decay; the oriental versions reportedly read "death."
- q (8:63) In the Clementine Latin the words "Then I replied" stand at the end of verse 62; they are placed here at the start of verse 63.

Chapter 9

1 He replied, "Measure the time carefully within yourself; and when you see that a certain part of the signs foretold has gone by, 2 you will know that this is the hour at which the Most High will begin to visit the world of his making. 3 And when there appear in the world quakings of places, tumult of peoples,[a] 4 then you will understand that it was of these things the Most High spoke, from the days that were before you, from the beginning. 5 For just as everything made in the world has a beginning and likewise a completion, and the completion is plain to see, 6 so too the times of the Most High have beginnings plain to see in portents and mighty acts, and completions in deeds and in signs. 7 And it shall be that everyone who is saved, and who is able to escape by his works, or by the faith with which you have believed,[b] 8 will be left alive out of the perils foretold, and will see my salvation in my land and within my borders, which I have consecrated for myself from eternity. 9 Then those who have now misused my ways will be in anguish,[c] and those who have cast them aside with contempt will abide in torments. 10 For those who did not acknowledge me while they lived, though they received my benefits, 11 and those who loathed my law while they still had freedom, 12 and who, while room for repentance was still open to them, did not understand but scorned it, these must come to know it after death, in torment. 13 So do not go on being curious as to how the ungodly will be tormented; rather inquire how the righteous will be saved, whose the world is, for whom the world exists, and when."

14 I replied, 15 "I said it before, I say it now, and I will say it again: those
who perish are more than those who will be saved, 16 as a wave is
greater than a drop."
17 He replied,[d] "As the field is, so are the seeds; as the flowers are, so are
their colors; as the worker is, so is the product; and as the farmer is, so
is his tillage. For it was the time of the world.[e] 18 When I was preparing
the world for those who now exist, before it was made for them to
dwell in, no one opposed me;[f] 19 for no one then existed. But now
those who have been created in this world that was prepared, with
its unfailing harvest and its unsearchable law, have become corrupt
in their ways. 20 Then I looked upon my world, and there it lay ruined;
my earth was in danger through the schemes of those who had come
into it.[g] 21 I looked and spared some, though with great difficulty, and
kept for myself one grape from a cluster and one plant from a great
forest.[h] 22 So let the multitude perish which was born in vain, and let
my grape be saved, and my plant; for with much labor I have brought
them to perfection.
23 "Now, if you will let yet another seven days pass—but do not fast in
them; 24 instead, find a field of flowers where there is no house, and
eat nothing there but what grows wild in the field; eat no meat and
drink no wine, only flowers— 25 and pray to the Most High without
ceasing; and I will come and speak with you."
26 So I went, as he had told me, into the field called Ardath,[i] and
sat there among the flowers and ate the plants of the field, and the
food they gave me was enough for me. 27 After seven days, as I lay
on the grass, my heart was troubled again as before. 28 My mouth
was opened, and I began to speak before the Most High: 29 "Lord,
you showed yourself to our ancestors in the wilderness, in a place
untrodden and unfruitful, when they were coming out of Egypt; and
you declared, 30 'Hear me, Israel; and you, offspring of Jacob, attend
to my words. 31 For see, I am sowing my law in you, and it shall
bring forth fruit in you, and you shall be glorified in it for ever.' 32 But
our ancestors received the law and did not keep it, nor observe the
statutes; yet the fruit of the law did not perish, nor could it, for it
was yours.[j] 33 Those who received it perished, because they did not

guard what had been sown in them. 34 Now this is the usual course: when the ground receives seed, or the sea a ship, or any vessel food or drink, and that into which the seed was sown or the thing put is destroyed, 35 then what was sown or put in, or what was received, is destroyed along with it; the things received no longer remain with us. But with us it has not been so. 36 For we who received the law have sinned and perished, and our heart also which received it; 37 but the law has not perished; it remains in its glory."[k]

38 While these things were in my heart, I glanced about, and there to my right was a woman, lamenting and crying aloud, grieving deeply in her soul; her garments were rent, and ashes lay on her head. 39 So I put aside the thoughts with which I was occupied, turned to her, 40 and said, "Why are you weeping? Why are you grieved in soul?" 41 She said to me, "Let me be, my lord, so that I may bewail myself and add to my grief, for I am deeply embittered in spirit and brought very low." 42 I said to her, "What has befallen you? Tell me." 43 She said to me, "I, your servant, was barren and had no child, though I had a husband thirty years. 44 Hour after hour, day after day, all through those thirty years, I entreated the Most High by night and by day. 45 After thirty years God heard your servant, saw how low I was, took notice of my distress, and gave me a son. My husband, my neighbors and I were overjoyed with him, and we gave great honor to the Mighty One. 46 I brought him up with much toil. 47 And when he had grown and the time came for him to take a wife, I prepared a feast day.

Notes

- a (9:3) The oriental versions reportedly add, "confusion of nations, and disquiet of rulers."
- b (9:7) Compare 13:23. The Latin here reads "the faith in which you have believed," addressing the readers directly.
- c (9:9) Latin miserebuntur, "will be pitiable" or "will be wretched."
- d (9:17) In the Clementine Latin the words "He replied" stand at the end of verse 16; they are placed at the head of the answer.
- e (9:17) The meaning of the last sentence is uncertain.
- f (9:18) Latin "When I was preparing for them, for those who now are, before the world was made in which they would dwell, no one contradicted me." The rendering combines the end of verse 18 with the start of verse 19, following the sense of the oriental versions as reported.

- g (9:20) The words “and saw that it was lost; I saw my earth” are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported, where the Latin reads only “and behold, it was in peril.”
- h (9:21) Compare Isaiah 65:8. Latin de tribu multa, “from a great tribe”; the rendering “forest” follows the oriental versions as reported.
- i (9:26) The name Ardath is of unknown meaning and location; the oriental versions reportedly read Arpad, Araat, or similar forms.
- j (9:32) Latin “and the fruit of the law did not appear (or obey); nor could it, for it was yours.” The rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- k (9:37) Latin in suo labore, “in its labor,” apparently a corruption; the oriental versions reportedly read “in its glory.”

Chapter 10

1 “But when my son went into his bridal chamber, he fell down and
died. 2 Then we all overturned the lamps,[a] and all my townspeople
rose up to console me; and I kept still until the evening of the next
day. 3 When they had all left off consoling me, so that I might be quiet,
I got up by night and fled, and came, as you see, to this field. 4 And I
mean never to go back into the city, but to stay here, neither eating
nor drinking, but mourning and fasting without a break until I die.”
5 Then I left the reflections in which I had been engaged, and answered
her in anger: 6 “You most foolish of women, do you not see our grief,
and what has happened to us? 7 For Zion, the mother of us all, is in
deep sorrow and great humiliation, and mourns most bitterly. 8 And
now, when we all mourn and are sad because we are all in sorrow,
are you grieving over one son? 9 Ask the earth, and she will tell you:
she is the one who should mourn so many that have grown up on
her. 10 From her all have been born from the beginning, and others
will come; and look, nearly all go to perdition, and their multitude
is brought to destruction. 11 Who, then, has more reason to mourn:
she who has lost so great a multitude, or you, who grieve for one?
12 But if you say to me, ‘My lament is not like the earth’s, for I have
lost the fruit of my womb, which I bore in grief and brought forth
in pain; 13 but with the earth it is the way of the earth: the multitude
now in her has gone as it came’—then I say to you: 14 just as you gave
birth with travail, so the earth from the beginning has given her fruit,
humankind, to him who made her. 15 Now therefore keep your grief

to yourself, and bear bravely the misfortunes that have befallen you.
16 For if you own God's decree as just, in due season you will have
your son back,[b] and among women you will win praise. 17 So go into
the city to your husband."
18 She said to me,[c] "I will not do it. I will not go into the city; I will
die here." 19 So I spoke to her once more, and said: 20 "Do not say such
a thing, but let yourself be persuaded; for how many are the misfor-
tunes of Zion! Take comfort because of the sorrow of Jerusalem. 21
For you see that our holy place has been laid waste, our altar thrown
down, our temple destroyed; 22 our harp is brought low, our hymn
silenced, our rejoicing ended; the light of our lampstand is put out,
the ark of our covenant plundered, our holy things defiled, and the
name by which we are called all but profaned; our children have
suffered insult, our priests have been burned, our Levites have gone
into captivity, our virgins have been defiled and our wives ravished,
our righteous men carried off, our little ones lost, our young men
enslaved, and our strong men made weak. 23 And worst of all, the seal
of Zion: she has been unsealed[d] from her glory and handed over to
those who hate us. 24 So throw off your deep sadness and set aside
your crowd of sorrows, so that the Mighty One may be reconciled
with you again, and the Most High may give you rest, relief from
your troubles."
25 While I was speaking to her, all at once her face shone exceedingly,
and her countenance flashed like lightning, so that I was greatly
afraid to go near her, and wondered what this might be. 26 Suddenly
she let out a loud cry, full of fear, so that the earth shook at the
sound. I looked, 27 and the woman was no longer visible to me, but
there was a city being built,[e] and a place showed itself with massive
foundations. I was afraid and cried aloud: 28 "Where is Uriel the angel,
who came to me at the first? It is he who has made me fall into this
great bewilderment; my end has become corruption, and my prayer a
reproach." 29 While I was saying this, he came to me and looked at me.
30 There I lay like a dead man, bereft of understanding. He took hold
of my right hand, gave me strength, set me on my feet, and said to
me, 31 "What is wrong with you? Why are your understanding and the

thoughts of your heart troubled? Why are you disturbed?" 32 I said,
"Because you forsook me! I did as you told me, and went out into the
field, and look, I have seen, and still see, what I cannot describe." 33 He
told me, "Stand up like a man, and I will counsel you." 34 I said, "Speak
to me, my lord; do not forsake me, lest I die before my time.[f] 35 Things
unknown to me I have beheld, and things beyond my knowing I am
hearing. 36 Can it be that my senses are cheated, and my soul is in
a dream? 37 Now, then, I entreat you to explain to your servant this
bewildering vision."
38 He answered, "Listen to me, and I will teach you and explain the
things you fear; the Most High has revealed many secrets to you. 39
He has seen your upright way: that you have grieved without ceasing
for your people, and mourned greatly over Zion. 40 This, then, is the
meaning of the vision that appeared to you a little while ago. 41 You
saw a woman mourning, and you began to console her; 42 but now
you no longer see the form of a woman; instead a city being built has
appeared to you. 43 And as for her telling you of the misfortune of her
son, this is the explanation: 44 This woman whom you saw is Zion,
whom you now see as a city built.[g] 45 And as for her telling you that
she was barren thirty years, it is because for three thousand years[h]
no offering had yet been offered in her. 46 Then, after three thousand
years, Solomon built the city and offered offerings; that was when the
barren woman bore a son. 47 Her words that she reared him with toil
signify the time of dwelling in Jerusalem. 48 And as for her telling you,
'My son died when he entered his bridal chamber, and misfortune
befell him,' that was the ruin which came upon Jerusalem. 49 And look,
you have seen her likeness, how she mourned her son, and you began
to console her for what had befallen her. These were the things to
be disclosed to you. 50 For now the Most High, seeing that you were
grieved to the depths of your soul and suffered with all your heart
on her account, has shown you the brightness of her glory and the
loveliness of her beauty. 51 That is why I told you to stay in the field
where no house had been built; 52 I was aware that the Most High
meant to begin revealing these things to you. 53 That was why I bade
you come to open ground, where no building had a foundation. 54 for

no work of human building could endure in the place where the city of the Most High was to be shown. 55 Do not fear, then, and let no terror seize your heart; enter, and behold how splendid and how vast the edifice is, so far as your eyes have power to see it; 56 and afterward you will hear as much as your ears can take in. 57 For you are blessed beyond many, and are called before the Most High as only a few are. 58 But tomorrow night you are to remain here, 59 and the Most High will show you in dreams[i] those visions of what he will do to the inhabitants of the earth in the last days." I slept that night and the following one, just as he had told me.[j]

Notes

- a (10:2) Latin evertimus omnes lumina, "we all overturned the lamps," a sign of mourning; the oriental versions reportedly read "put out the lamps."
- b (10:16) Latin "you will receive his counsel in time"; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported.
- c (10:18) In the Clementine Latin the words "She said to me" stand at the end of verse 17; they are placed at the head of her reply.
- d (10:23) Latin resignata, "unsealed," that is, her seal is broken and her glory taken away.
- e (10:27) The heavenly Jerusalem (compare 7:26; 8:52; 13:36).
- f (10:34) Latin ut non frustra moriar, "lest I die in vain."
- g (10:44) The Latin of this verse is broken; the rendering follows the sense.
- h (10:45) Latin triginta, "thirty"; the oriental versions reportedly read "three thousand years," referring to the years from creation to Solomon's temple, and the rendering follows that reading in verses 45–46 in place of the Latin "thirty."
- i (10:59) Latin visiones supremorum, "visions of the highest (or last) things"; the words "in dreams" follow the oriental versions as reported.
- j (10:59) In the Clementine Latin the last sentence is a separate verse (10:60), so that the chapter has 60 verses; the numbering of most English versions is followed here.

Chapter 11

1 On the second night[a] I had a dream: there was an eagle rising up from the sea, with twelve feathered wings and three heads.[b] 2 I looked: over all the land it stretched out its wings, every wind of the sky breathed on it, and the clouds[c] massed together around it. 3 I watched, and from its wings there grew opposing wings,[d] and these became little, puny wings. 4 Its heads lay quiet; the one in the middle was bigger than its fellows, yet it also lay quiet along with them. 5 I watched, and the

eagle flew with its wings and reigned over the earth and over those
who dwell in it. 6 I saw that everything under heaven was subject to it,
and no one spoke against it, not one creature on the earth. 7 I watched,
and the eagle rose up on its talons and gave a cry to its wings, saying,
8 "Do not all keep watch at once; let each sleep in its own place, and
keep watch in turn; 9 but let the heads be kept for the last." 10 I looked,
and the cry came not out of its heads, but out of the midst of its body.
11 Then I numbered its opposing wings: eight in all. 12 I watched, and
on the right side one wing arose and reigned over all the earth. 13 And
while it was reigning, its end came, and it disappeared, so that its
place was not seen. The next arose and reigned, and it held sway a
long time. 14 And while it was reigning, its end came too, so that it
vanished like the first. 15 Then a voice sounded, saying to it, 16 "Listen,
you who have ruled the earth for so long; before you begin to vanish,
this is my announcement to you: 17 after you, no one will hold sway
as long as you, or even half as long."[e] 18 Then the third raised itself up
and held the rule like those before, and it also disappeared. 19 And so it
befell all the wings one after another, to bear rule and then to vanish
from sight. 20 I watched, and in due course the wings that followed
were raised up on the right side,[f] that they also might hold the rule;
and some of them held it, but at once disappeared; 21 and some of them
were raised up, but did not hold the rule. 22 After this I looked: gone
were the twelve wings, gone two of the small wings, 23 and nothing
was left on the eagle's body except the two heads that were at rest
and six little wings. 24 I watched, and two of the six little wings broke
away and stayed under the head on the right side; but four stayed
where they were. 25 I watched, and these underwings planned to raise
themselves up and hold the rule. 26 I watched, and one was raised up,
but at once vanished; 27 and the second vanished even more swiftly
than the first. 28 I watched, and the two that remained were plotting
between themselves to reign as well. 29 And while they were plotting,
one of the heads that were at rest, the one in the middle, woke up;
for it was greater than the other two heads. 30 And I perceived that
it joined the pair of heads to itself, 31 and that head, together with
its companions, swung round and swallowed up the two underwings

that were scheming for the kingdom. 32 This head struck terror into the whole earth, and lorded it over earth's dwellers with great oppression, and held power over the world more than all the wings that had been. 33 After this I looked, and suddenly the middle head too disappeared, just as the wings had. 34 But two heads remained, and they also reigned in like manner over the earth and those who dwell in it. 35 I looked, and the head on the right side swallowed up the head on the left.

36 Then I heard a voice telling me, "Look in front of you, and consider what you see." 37 I looked, and there came a lion-like creature, stirred up out of the woods and roaring; and I heard it speak with a man's voice to the eagle, addressing it thus: 38 "Hear, for I have words for you. Thus says the Most High: 39 Are you not the survivor of the four beasts[g] whom I set to rule in my world, that through them the close of their times might arrive? 40 You, the fourth, coming last, overcame every beast that was before you, and ruled the world with great terror, and the whole globe with cruel oppression; for long ages you have inhabited the earth by fraud. 41 You have judged the earth, but not with truth; 42 for you have afflicted the meek and injured the peaceable; you have loved liars, destroyed the dwellings of the fruitful, and torn down the walls of those who did you no harm. 43 Your insolence has gone up to the Most High, and your pride to the Mighty One. 44 The Most High has looked upon his[h] times, and see, they are ended, and his ages are complete. 45 Therefore vanish, eagle—you, your dreadful wings, your wicked small wings, your spiteful heads, your evil claws, and all your empty body— 46 so that the whole earth may be refreshed and relieved, set free from your violence, and may hope for the judgment and mercy of him who made it."

Notes

- a (11:1) The fifth vision (11:1–12:51) is the vision of the eagle. The words "On the second night" are not in the Clementine Latin, which begins "And I saw a dream"; they are reportedly found in other witnesses.
- b (11:1) The eagle stands for the Roman Empire (12:11), identified with the fourth kingdom of Daniel 7:7, 23. The wings and heads are generally understood as Roman emperors; the three heads are often taken to be Vespasian, Titus, and Domitian (AD 69–96), but the identifications are disputed.

- c (11:2) Latin “and they were gathered together”; the words “the clouds … about it” are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported.
- d (11:3) Latin contrariae pennae, “opposing wings,” perhaps rival claimants or lesser rulers.
- e (11:17) Often taken to refer to Augustus, who ruled the empire for over forty years (27 BC–AD 14).
- f (11:20) Latin “from the right side”; the text of verses 20–21 is uncertain.
- g (11:39) The four beasts of Daniel 7:3–7.
- h (11:44) Latin superba tempora, “the proud times”; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported, “his (that is, God’s) times.” The Latin scelera ejus, “its crimes,” is likewise rendered from the oriental versions, as reported.

Chapter 12

1 While the lion was speaking these words to the eagle, I looked, 2 and there was the head that had remained; and the four wings[a] that had gone over to it had disappeared, though they had been raised up to reign; and their reign was feeble and full of tumult. 3 I looked, and they too had vanished, and the whole body of the eagle was set on fire, and the earth was struck with great dread. Then out of the tumult and the frenzy of my mind, and out of my great fear, I woke, and said to my spirit, 4 “Look, you have brought this on me, because you investigate the ways of the Most High. 5 Look, my mind is worn out still, my spirit is utterly weak, and hardly any strength remains in me, so greatly was I terrified this night. 6 So now I will pray to the Most High to strengthen me to the end.”

7 I said, “Lord and Master, if I have found favor in your sight, and if I am counted righteous before you above many, and if my supplication has truly come up before your face, 8 strengthen me, and show your servant the interpretation and the clear meaning of this fearful vision, so that you may fully console my soul. 9 For you have judged me worthy to be shown the last of the times.”

10 He told me,[b] “This is the interpretation of this vision of yours: 11 The eagle that you saw rising from the sea is the kingdom which appeared in a vision to your brother Daniel.[c] 12 But it was not interpreted to him as I now interpret it to you. 13 Look, the days are coming when a kingdom will rise on the earth, and it will be more dreadful than all the kingdoms that were before it. 14 Twelve kings will reign in it, one

after another. 15 But the second to begin reigning will hold sway for a
longer time than any of the twelve. 16 This is the meaning of the twelve
wings you saw. 17 As for the voice you heard speaking, not issuing
from its heads but from the midst of its body, 18 this is the meaning:
after the time of that kingdom[d] no small strife will arise, and it will
be in danger of falling; yet it will not fall then, but will be restored to
its former state. 19 As for your seeing eight underwings clinging to its
wings, 20 this is the meaning: eight kings will arise in it, whose times
will be brief and their years swift; two of them will perish. 21 As the
middle of its time draws near, four will be kept until the time when its
end begins to approach; but two will be kept for the end. 22 As for your
seeing three heads at rest, 23 this is the meaning: in its final days the
Most High will raise up three kings,[e] and they will renew many things
in it and rule over the earth 24 and its dwellers with more oppression
than all who were before them. That is why they are called the heads
of the eagle; 25 for it is they who will sum up its godlessness, and who
will bring its last days to completion. 26 As for your seeing the greater
head disappear, this is its meaning: one of them will die on his bed,
yet in torments.[f] 27 As for the two who remain, the sword will devour
them. 28 For the sword of the one will devour his companion; but he
too will fall by the sword in the last days.[g] 29 As for your seeing two
underwings passing over to the head on the right side, 30 this is the
meaning: these are the ones whom the Most High has kept for its end;
this is the feeble reign, full of turmoil, as you saw. 31 As for the lion
that you saw roused out of the forest, roaring and speaking to the
eagle and reproving it for its wrongdoing in all the words you heard,
32 this is the Anointed One,[h] reserved by the Most High for the close of
the days, sprung from David's line, who will come and address them.
He will rebuke them for their godlessness and their wicked deeds,
and will lay before them their acts of contempt.[i] 33 For first he will set
them alive in judgment, and when he has reproved them, then he will
destroy them. 34 Yet my people who are left, the ones saved within my
borders, he will set free with compassion, and gladden them until the
end arrives, the day of judgment, of which I told you at the outset. 35
This is the dream that you saw, and this is its interpretation. 36 And

you alone have been worthy to learn this secret of the Most High.
37 So write all these things that you have seen in a book, and put it
in a hidden place; 38 and teach them to the wise among your people;
you know that their hearts are able to understand and preserve these
secrets. 39 But as for you, wait here seven more days, so that whatever
it pleases the Most High to show you may be shown to you." Then he
left me.[j]
40 When all the people heard that seven days had passed and I had not
gone back to the city, they all gathered, from the least to the greatest,
and came to me and said to me, 41 "How have we sinned against you,
and what wrong have we done to you, that you have abandoned us
and sit in this place? 42 For of all the peoples you alone are left to us,
like a cluster from the vintage, like a lamp in a dark place, like a haven
and a ship saved from the storm. 43 Are not the evils that have befallen
us enough? 44 If you abandon us, how much better it would have been
if we too had been consumed when Zion burned! 45 We are not better
than the ones who perished there." Then they wailed aloud.
46 "Take courage, Israel; and do not be sad, house of Jacob. 47 For you
are remembered before the Most High, and the Mighty One has not
forgotten you in your trial.[k] 48 I have not forsaken you, nor gone away
from you; but I came to this place to pray over the desolation of Zion,
and to seek mercy for the low estate of your sanctuary. 49 Now go,
each of you, to your house, and I will come to you after these days." 50
So the people went into the city, as I told them. 51 But I sat in the field
seven days, as he had commanded me; and in those days I ate only
the flowers of the field, and my food was of plants.

Notes

- a (12:2) Latin "the four wings"; perhaps the four little wings of 11:24.
- b (12:10) In the Latin, "And he said to me" stands at the end of verse 9; it is placed at the head of the reply.
- c (12:11) Daniel 7:7–8, 23–27. Here the fourth kingdom of Daniel, originally the Greek empire, is reinterpreted as Rome.
- d (12:18) Usually taken as the civil wars of AD 68–69 after the death of Nero, when the empire nearly fell and was restored under Vespasian.
- e (12:23) Latin regna, "kingdoms"; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions, as reported.

- f (12:26) Often taken as Vespasian, who died a natural death in AD 79.
- g (12:28) The Latin of verse 28 is confused. It is commonly taken to refer to Domitian, who was popularly (and probably wrongly) believed to have killed his brother Titus, and who was himself assassinated in AD 96.
- h (12:32) "Anointed One" is Messiah (Hebrew) or Christ (Greek). The Latin reads ventus, "wind," evidently a corruption; the rendering follows the oriental versions as reported, which also supply the words "until the end of days ... and speak to them."
- i (12:32) Latin discerptiones, "acts of contempt" or "insults"; the meaning is uncertain.
- j (12:39) In the Latin, "Then he left me" stands at the beginning of verse 40.
- k (12:47) Latin in tentatione, "in temptation" or "in trial."

Chapter 13

1 After seven days I dreamed a dream by night.[a] 2 There was a wind
rising out of the sea, which stirred up all its waves. 3 As I watched,
that wind brought something up from the depths of the sea that
looked like a man;[b] and this man flew with the clouds of heaven.[c]
Wherever he turned his face, everything under his gaze trembled; 4
and wherever the voice went forth from his mouth, all who heard
his voice melted away, as wax melts[d] when it feels the fire. 5 After
this I looked, and a multitude of people past numbering was being
gathered from the four winds of heaven to make war on the man
who had come up out of the sea. 6 I watched, and he carved a great
mountain out for himself and flew up onto it. 7 I sought to see the
region or place from which the mountain had been carved, and could
not. 8 After this I looked, and all who had gathered against him to
fight him were seized with great fear, yet they dared to fight. 9 And
when he saw the onrush of the multitude as it came, he did not lift
his hand, nor hold a spear[e] or any weapon of war; but I saw only 10
but only how he poured out of his mouth what looked like a torrent
of fire, and out of his lips a fiery blast, and out of his tongue he hurled
sparks and tempests; and all of these mingled together, the torrent
of fire, the fiery blast, and the mighty tempest, 11 and fell upon the
onrushing multitude prepared for battle, and burned them all up, so
that suddenly nothing was to be seen of that countless multitude but
only dust of ashes and the smell of smoke. I saw it and was astounded.

12 After this I saw that man coming down from the mountain and call-
ing to himself another multitude, a peaceable one. 13 Then the forms
of many people came to him, some of them glad and some sorrowful;
some were in bonds, and some were bringing others as offerings.[f]
Then I fell sick from the greatness of my fear; I woke, and said, 14
"From the beginning you have shown your servant these wonders,
and you have considered me worthy to have my plea received; 15 now
show me also the interpretation of this dream. 16 For as I reckon in
my understanding, woe to those who are left in those days, and much
more woe to those who are not left! 17 For those who are not left will
be in sorrow, 18 since they understand what is laid up for the last days,
but will not attain it.[g] But woe also to those who are left, 19 for this
very reason, that they will see great perils and much distress, as these
dreams show. 20 Yet it is better to come into these things, though in
peril, than to pass away like a cloud from the world and not see what
will happen at the last."
21 He answered,[h] "I will tell you what the vision means, and I will
also explain to you the things you spoke of. 22 Concerning your words
about the ones who are left, here is the meaning: 23 the one who causes
the danger in that season will keep safe the ones who meet with
danger, if they have works and faith toward the Almighty.[i] 24 Know
this, then: those who remain are more blessed than those who have
died. 25 Here is what the vision signifies: you beheld a man ascending
out of the sea's heart; 26 this is he whom the Most High is keeping for
many ages, who will himself set free his creation; and he will order
the lot of those who are left. 27 As for your seeing wind and fire and
storm come out of his mouth, 28 and that he held no spear or weapon
of war, yet his onrush destroyed the multitude that came to make
war on him, this is the meaning: 29 the days are coming when the
Most High will begin to deliver those who are on the earth. 30 And
bewilderment of mind[j] will come upon the dwellers on earth. 31 They
will plan to make war on one another: a city on a city, a region on a
region, a nation on a nation, and one kingdom on another. 32 When
these things happen, and the signs occur that I showed you earlier,
then my son[k] will be revealed, the one you saw rising from the sea as

a man. 33 And when all the nations hear his voice, each of them will
leave behind, in its own land, the warfare that they wage against one
another; 34 and a countless multitude will be gathered together, as you
saw, wishing to come and make war on him. 35 But he will stand on the
summit of Mount Zion. 36 And Zion will come into view, prepared and
built, for all to see, just like the mountain you saw cut out without
hands.[l] 37 And he, my son, will reprove the nations that have come
for their godlessness—this was signified by the storm[m]— 38 and will
set before them their evil thoughts and the torments with which they
will be tormented, which were signified by the flame; and he will
destroy them without labor by the law, which was signified by the
fire. 39 You beheld him summon another throng to himself, a peaceable
one: 40 these are the ten tribes which were led away captive from their
own land in the days of King Hoshea,[n] whom Shalmaneser[o] the king
of the Assyrians led captive; he carried them across the River, and
they were taken into another land. 41 But they made a plan among
themselves to leave the crowd of nations and go to a more distant
region, where human beings had never lived, 42 that there at least they
might keep their statutes, which they had not kept in their own land.
43 And they went in by the narrow passages of the Euphrates River. 44
For then the Most High performed signs for them and held back the
channels of the river until they had crossed. 45 The road through that
country was long, a march of eighteen months; and the region bears
the name Arzareth.[p] 46 There they have dwelt until the last time; and
now, when they are about to come again, 47 the Most High will once
more hold back the river's channels to let them pass over. This is why
the throng you beheld was at peace. 48 But those of your people who
are left are those who are found within my holy border.[q] 49 So when
he destroys the multitude of the nations that are gathered together,
he will protect the people who remain. 50 And then he will show them
very many wonders."
51 I said, "Lord and Master, explain this to me: why did I see the man
rising from the heart of the sea?" He told me,
52 "Just as no one can search out or know what is deep within the sea,
so nobody on earth is able to see my son or his companions, except in

his own time.[r] 53 This is the interpretation of the dream that you saw;
and on account of it you alone have been enlightened here. 54 For you
have forsaken your own ways, and have given yourself to mine, and
have searched out my law. 55 You have ordered your life in wisdom,
and have called understanding your mother. 56 That is why I have
shown you this; for there is a reward with the Most High. After three
more days I will tell you other things, and set before you weighty and
wonderful matters."
57 So I went out to the field, glorifying and praising the Most High
greatly for the marvels he works at their appointed times, 58 and
because he rules the seasons and all that is brought about in them.
Three days I remained there.

Notes

- a (13:1) The sixth vision (13:1–58), the man from the sea.
- b (13:3) The Latin lacks the words "that wind … the figure of a man"; they are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported, since a line has evidently dropped out of the Latin.
- c (13:3) Latin convalescebat cum millibus caeli, "grew strong with the thousands of heaven," evidently a corruption; the rendering follows the oriental versions as reported. Compare Daniel 7:13, "one like a son of man, coming with the clouds of heaven."
- d (13:4) Latin "as the earth is at rest when it feels fire," evidently corrupt; the rendering follows the oriental versions as reported. Compare Psalm 97:5; Micah 1:4.
- e (13:9) Latin framea, a Germanic spear; here simply "spear."
- f (13:13) The Latin of this verse is obscure; compare Isaiah 66:20, where the nations bring the scattered Israelites as an offering.
- g (13:18) The Latin of verses 17–18 is confused; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions, as reported.
- h (13:21) In the Latin, "And he answered me and said" stands at the end of verse 20.
- i (13:23) Latin Fortissimum, "the Mightiest One." The Latin of this verse is obscure.
- j (13:30) Latin excessus mentis, "frenzy" or "ecstasy" of mind.
- k (13:32) The Latin filius meus, "my son," here and in verses 37 and 52 and in 14:9, reportedly corresponds to "my servant" in some oriental versions, and may render Greek pais, which can mean either "son" or "servant." Compare 7:28–29.
- l (13:36) Compare Daniel 2:34, 45, the stone cut out without hands.
- m (13:37) Latin of verses 37–38 is confused; the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions, as reported, which explain the storm, the flame, and the fire of verses 10–11.

- n (13:40) Hoshea ("salvation"), last king of the northern kingdom of Israel (2 Kings 17:1–6), about 732–722 BC.
- o (13:40) Shalmaneser V, king of Assyria, 727–722 BC; the name means "(the god) Shulmanu is foremost."
- p (13:45) Arzareth (Latin Arsareth) is probably a corruption of Hebrew erets aheret, "another land," from Deuteronomy 29:28, the verse that later rabbinic tradition applied to the lost ten tribes.
- q (13:48) Latin "within my border"; the word "holy" is supplied from the oriental versions, as reported.
- r (13:52) Latin nisi in tempore diei, "except in the time of the day"; the oriental versions reportedly read "of his day."

Chapter 14

1 On the third day, as I was sitting under an oak,[a] 2 when out of a bush facing me a voice spoke: "Ezra, Ezra!" I answered, "Here I am, Lord," and stood up on my feet. He told me, 3 "I revealed myself openly in the bush and spoke to Moses, when my people were slaves in Egypt; 4 and I sent him and led my people out of Egypt, and brought him up on Mount Sinai, and kept him with me many days. 5 I told him many wondrous things, and showed him the secrets of the times and the end;[b] and I commanded him, saying, 6 'These words you shall make public, and these you shall keep hidden.' 7 And now I say to you: 8 store in your heart the signs I have shown you, the dreams you have seen, and the interpretations you have heard; 9 for you will be taken from human beings, and from then on you will dwell with my son[c] and with others like you, until the times are over. 10 For the world has lost its youth, and the times are drawing near to old age. 11 For the world[d] is split into twelve portions; nine portions are gone already, and half of the tenth; 12 and there remain of it two parts, besides half of the tenth part.[e] 13 Now therefore set your house in order, warn your people, comfort the lowly among them, and renounce now the life of corruption. 14 Put away from you mortal thoughts, cast off from you the burdens of humankind, strip off now your feeble nature, set aside the thoughts that trouble you most, and hasten to depart from these times. 15 For evils worse than those you have now seen happen will be done hereafter. 16 For the feebler the world grows with age, so much the more will evils abound upon its dwellers. 17 Truth will withdraw

farther off, and falsehood draw near; for the eagle[f] you saw in the vision is already hastening to come."
18 Then I replied, "Let me speak before you, Lord. 19 Look, I will go, as you have ordered me, and I will warn the people living now; but who will warn those who are born later? 20 For the world lies in darkness, and its dwellers are without light. 21 For your law has been burned,[g] and so no one knows the things that have been done by you, or the works that are to begin. 22 But if I have found favor before you, send the Holy Spirit into me, and I will set down everything done in the world since its beginning, all that stood written in your law, that people may find the path, and that any who desire life in the last days may live."
23 He answered, "Go, gather the people, and tell them not to look for you for forty days. 24 But get ready many writing tablets,[h] and take with you Sarea, Dabria, Selemia, Ethanus and Asiel,[i] these five, since they are trained to write quickly; 25 Then come back here; I will light a lamp of understanding in your heart, and it will burn until you finish the writing you start. 26 When the work is done, part of it you are to publish, and part you are to hand on secretly to the wise. At this hour tomorrow the writing will begin."
27 So I went, as he had commanded me, and gathered all the people, and said, 28 "Hear these words, Israel. 29 At the first our ancestors dwelt as strangers in Egypt, and they were set free from there, 30 and received the law of life, which they did not keep, and which you also have transgressed after them. 31 Afterward a land was granted to you as an inheritance in the land of Zion; yet you and your forebears committed iniquity and failed to walk in the ways the Most High laid down for you. 32 And because he is a righteous judge, in due time he took back what he had given you. 33 And now you are here, and your kindred are farther inland than you.[j] 34 So if you master your understanding and discipline your heart, you will stay alive, and after death you will receive mercy. 35 For after death the judgment will come, when we live once more; and then the names of the righteous will become manifest, and the deeds of the godless will be disclosed. 36 But let no one come to me now, nor seek me for forty days."

37 So I took the five men, as he commanded me, and we went out into
the field and stayed there. 38 Next day a voice summoned me: "Ezra,
open your mouth, and drink the draught I offer you." 39 So I opened my
mouth, and a full cup was handed to me; it was filled with something
that looked like water, but its color was like fire. 40 I received it and
drank; and as soon as I had drunk, understanding welled up from
my heart, wisdom grew within my breast, and my spirit held fast its
memory;[k] 41 and my mouth was opened, and was not closed again. 42
The Most High gave understanding to the five men, and they wrote
what was spoken, in turn, in characters which they did not know.[l]
They sat forty days; 43 they ate their bread by night;[m] but as for me, I
spoke by day, and by night I was not silent. 44 So in forty days ninety-
four[n] books were written. 45 At the end of the forty days the Most High
said to me, "The twenty-four books[o] you wrote first, publish openly,
for the worthy and unworthy alike to read; 46 the seventy written
afterward, however, you are to keep and hand on to the wise of your
people. 47 For in them is the spring of understanding, the fountain of
wisdom, and the river of knowledge." 48 And I did so.[p]

Notes

- a (14:1) The seventh vision (14:1–48), Ezra and the restoration of the scriptures. The oak recalls Abraham at Mamre (Genesis 18:1).
- b (14:5) Compare 2 Baruch 59:4–11, where Moses is likewise shown the secrets of the end on Sinai.
- c (14:9) See the note on 13:32.
- d (14:11) Latin saeculum. The division of world history into twelve parts is reportedly lacking or different in some oriental versions.
- e (14:12) The Latin of verses 11–12 is reportedly confused in the manuscripts ("ten and a half parts have passed"); the rendering follows the sense of the oriental versions as reported, which agree that the greater part of the world's time is past.
- f (14:17) Latin "the vision which you saw"; the word "eagle" follows the oriental versions, as reported, referring to the eagle vision of chapters 11–12.
- g (14:21) Referring to the destruction of the temple and its scrolls by the Babylonians in 587 BC (compare 4:23). The story that Ezra restored the scriptures by inspiration is reflected in some early Christian writers.
- h (14:24) Latin buxos, "boxwood tablets," wooden tablets coated with wax for writing.
- i (14:24) The five scribes' names are reportedly uncertain and appear differently in the versions; the Latin reads Saream, Dabriam, Selemiam, Echanum, and Asiel.

Selemia is probably Shelemiah, “Yahweh has repaid”; Asiel probably means “God has made”; the others are of uncertain meaning.

- j (14:33) Latin introrsum vestrum, “within you” or “farther in,” probably referring to the ten tribes beyond the Euphrates (13:40–45).
- k (14:40) Latin “my spirit was kept in memory.”
- l (14:42) Latin excessiones noctis, “the outpourings of the night,” evidently a corruption; the rendering follows the oriental versions as reported. The “characters they did not know” are commonly taken to be the square Aramaic script, which in Jewish tradition Ezra introduced in place of the older Hebrew script.
- m (14:43) The Latin has “they ate bread at night” at the beginning of the verse; the words “They sat forty days” at the end of verse 42 are supplied from the oriental versions, as reported.
- n (14:44) Latin ducenti quattuor, “two hundred and four”; other Latin witnesses and the oriental versions reportedly read “ninety-four.” The seventy hidden books are esoteric writings such as this one.
- o (14:45) The twenty-four books are the Hebrew scriptures as counted in Jewish tradition (the Torah, the Prophets, and the Writings, with the Twelve counted as one book, and Ezra–Nehemiah and Chronicles each as one). The number “twenty-four” is supplied from the oriental versions, as reported; the Latin reads “the first books.”
- p (14:48) In the Clementine Latin these words end verse 47, and the book of 4 Ezra ends there. The eastern versions are said to go on with a closing statement dated to the seventh year of the sixth week, 5,000 years, three months and twelve days after the creation. It says that Ezra was then caught up and carried to the company of those like him once all these things were written, and that he received the title “Scribe of the knowledge of the Most High” for all time. This is the “taking up” referred to in 8:20 and 14:9. Most English versions number the words “And I did so” as verse 48.

Chapter 15

1 “See, speak in the hearing of my people the words of prophecy which
I will put in your mouth,[a] says the Lord; 2 and have them written
on paper,[b] for they are trustworthy and true. 3 Do not fear the plots
against you, and do not let the unbelief of those who speak against
you trouble you. 4 For every unbeliever will die in his unbelief.”
5 “Look, I am bringing evils upon the whole world, says the Lord:
sword and famine, death and ruin; 6 because iniquity has utterly
defiled the whole earth, and their harmful deeds have reached their
full measure. 7 Therefore, says the Lord, 8 I will not stay silent any
longer about their godlessness, which they practice so irreverently,

and I will not put up with their wicked ways. See, the blood of the innocent and righteous cries out to me, and the souls of the righteous call out without stopping. 9 I will surely avenge them, says the Lord, and will require from them all the innocent blood shed among them. 10 See, my people are led like a flock to the slaughter. I will no longer let them live in the land of Egypt, 11 but I will bring them out with a mighty hand and an uplifted arm, and will strike Egypt with plagues as before, and will destroy all its land. 12 Egypt will mourn, and its foundations will be struck with the blow and the chastisement that God will bring upon it. 13 Those who till the soil will mourn, because their seed will fail through blight and hail and a fearful star.[c] 14 Woe to the world and its dwellers! 15 For the sword and their ruin are drawing near; nation will rise up against nation in battle, with swords in their hands. 16 For there will be unrest among people; growing strong against one another, they will pay no heed to their king, and their princes will reckon their deeds by their own might.[d] 17 A person will long to go into a city, and will not be able to. 18 For because of their pride the cities will be in turmoil, the houses will be destroyed, and people will be afraid. 19 No one will pity a neighbor; they will attack one another's houses with the sword and plunder their goods, driven by hunger for bread and by great distress.

20 "See, says God, I am summoning all the kings of the earth to fear me, from the rising sun, from the south, from the east and from Lebanon,[e] to turn on one another and repay what has been done to them. 21 As they are doing to my chosen ones to this day, so I will do, and will repay into their laps. This is what the Lord God says: 22 My right hand will show no mercy to sinners, nor will my sword rest from any who pour out guiltless blood upon the earth." 23 And fire went out from his anger and consumed the foundations of the earth, and the sinners, like burning straw. 24 "Woe to those who sin and do not keep my commandments, says the Lord; 25 I will not spare them. Depart, you rebellious children,[f] and do not defile my sanctuary." 26 The Lord is aware of everyone who offends against him; that is why he has given them up to death and to slaughter. 27 For evils have already come upon

the whole earth, and you will remain in them; for God will not deliver you, because you have sinned against him.
28 See, a fearful sight, and its appearance from the east! 29 The nations of the dragons of Arabia[g] will come out with many chariots, and their vast numbers will sweep across the earth like the wind, so that everyone who hears them will fear and tremble. 30 The Carmonians,[h] raging in wrath, will go forth like wild boars of the forest, and come with great power, and join battle with them, and lay waste a portion of the land of the Assyrians with their teeth.[i] 31 And after this the dragons, remembering their origin, will gain the upper hand; and they will turn, conspiring together in great power, to pursue them. 32 And these will be thrown into confusion and fall silent before their power, and will turn their feet in flight. 33 And from the land of the Assyrians one lying in ambush will besiege them and destroy one of them; and there will be fear and trembling in their army, and strife among their kings.
34 See, clouds from the east, and from the north to the south! Their appearance is very dreadful, full of wrath and storm. 35 They will dash against one another, and will pour out a heavy storm[j] upon the earth, their own storm; and there will be blood from the sword as high as a horse's belly,[k] 36 and as high as a man's thigh and a camel's hock.[l] Fear and much trembling will be upon the earth; 37 those who see that wrath will shudder, and trembling will seize them. After this, great storm clouds will be stirred up 38 from the south and the north, and another part from the west. 39 But the winds from the east will prevail, and will shut in the cloud which he raised up in wrath; and the storm that was to bring destruction by the east wind and the west will be driven back.[m] 40 Then great and mighty clouds, full of wrath, will be lifted up, and the storm, to make the whole earth and its dwellers afraid; and they will pour out a terrible storm over every high and lofty place, 41 fire and hail, swords on the wing, and torrents of water, until every field and every stream is brimming with an abundance of waters. 42 They will tear down cities and walls, mountains and hills, the trees of the forests and the grass of the meadows, and their grain. 43 They will go on steadily as far as Babylon,[n] and will destroy it. 44

They will come to it and surround it, and pour out the storm and all their wrath upon it; then dust and smoke will go up to heaven, and all who are around it will mourn for it. 45 And those who survive under it will serve those who have struck it with terror.

46 "And you, Asia,[o] who share in the hope of Babylon and in her glorious repute, 47 woe to you, miserable one, because you have made yourself like her; you have dressed your daughters up for prostitution, to please and boast to your lovers, who have always lusted to commit prostitution with you. 48 You have copied the hated city in all that she does and in all her schemes. Therefore, says God, 49 I will send evils upon you: widowhood, poverty, famine, sword, and pestilence, to lay waste your houses with violence and death, and the glory of your strength.[p] 50 Like a flower you will wither, when the burning heat rises that is sent upon you. 51 You will be weakened like a poor woman, beaten and wounded,[q] so that your mighty ones and your lovers cannot receive you. 52 Would I have been so jealous against you, says the Lord, 53 if you had not always killed my chosen ones, exulting and clapping your hands and talking over their death when you were drunk? 54 Beautify your face! 55 The wages of your harlotry are in your lap; therefore you will receive your recompense. 56 What you do to my chosen, says the Lord, God will do in turn to you, giving you over to evil. 57 Your children will die of hunger, and you will be killed by the sword; your cities will be destroyed, and all your people in the open country will be killed by the sword.[r] 58 Those in the mountains will perish of hunger, and they will eat their own flesh and drink their own blood, for hunger of bread and thirst for water. 59 You will come, unhappy one, across the seas, and again you will meet with evils. 60 And as they pass by, they will dash against the city that was slain,[s] and will destroy some portion of your land, and wipe out part of your glory, as they return once more from Babylon laid waste. 61 You will be torn down by them like stubble, and they will be fire to you. 62 They will devour you and your cities, your land and your mountains; they will burn up with fire all your forests and your fruitful trees. 63 They will carry your children away captive, take your wealth as plunder, and wipe out the glory of your face."

Notes

- a (15:1) Chapters 15–16, known as 6 Ezra, are a Christian addition, reportedly from the 3rd century AD, perhaps written in the eastern Roman Empire during a time of persecution. A Greek fragment of 15:57–59 has reportedly been found in an Oxyrhynchus papyrus (P. Oxy. 1010), showing that this section was first written in Greek. These chapters are not in the oriental versions.
- b (15:2) Latin charta, "papyrus" or "paper."
- c (15:13) Latin sidus, "star" or "constellation"; in these chapters the word seems to stand for a destructive storm, and from verse 35 on it is rendered "storm."
- d (15:16) The Latin of this verse is obscure.
- e (15:20) "From the rising sun ... the east": Latin ab Oriente ... ab Euro, the latter properly the southeast wind. Lebanon ("white," from its snowy peaks) perhaps stands here for the north or west. The text may be corrupt.
- f (15:25) Latin discedite filii a potestate, "depart, children, from the power," obscure; perhaps "depart, you apostate children."
- g (15:29) Latin dracones Arabum, "dragons of the Arabians." Some interpreters see an allusion to the armies of Odenathus and Zenobia of Palmyra in the AD 260s, who fought the Persians; the identification is uncertain.
- h (15:30) Latin carmonii, probably the people of Carmania, a province of Persia on the north shore of the Persian Gulf; here perhaps the Persians under Shapur I (AD 240–270).
- i (15:30) The words "with their teeth" are not in the Clementine Latin; they are reportedly found in another Latin manuscript tradition. Assyria here may stand for Syria, which was overrun by the Persians in the AD 250s.
- j (15:35) See the note on verse 13.
- k (15:35) Compare 1 Enoch 100:3 and Revelation 14:20.
- l (15:36) Latin fimus hominis usque ad substramen cameli, "human dung up to the camel's litter," evidently corrupt; the rendering follows a common emendation, femur ("thigh") for fimus ("dung") and suffraginem ("hock") for substramen.
- m (15:39) The Latin of this verse is very obscure.
- n (15:43) Babylon, as in Revelation 17–18, stands for Rome.
- o (15:46) Asia here is the Roman province of Asia, in western Asia Minor (modern western Turkey); its chief cities included Ephesus, Smyrna, and Pergamum.
- p (15:49) Latin "with violence and death, and the glory of your strength"; the text is obscure.
- q (15:51) Latin castigata a mulieribus, "chastised by women," probably a corruption for "wounded."
- r (15:57) A Greek fragment of verses 57–59 has reportedly been found among the Oxyrhynchus papyri (see the note on 15:1).
- s (15:60) Latin civitatem occisam, "the slain city," obscure; perhaps meaning Rome laid waste, or a corruption.

Chapter 16

1 Woe to you, Babylon and Asia! Woe to you, Egypt and Syria![a] 2 Wrap
yourselves in sackcloth and haircloth, beat your breasts for your
children, and grieve; for your ruin is close at hand. 3 A sword has been
sent against you; who is there to turn it back? 4 A fire has been sent
among you; who is there to quench it? 5 Evils have been sent upon
you; who is there to drive them away? 6 Can anyone drive away a
hungry lion in the forest, or put out a fire in dry stubble once it has
started to blaze? 7 Can anyone turn back an arrow shot by a strong
archer? 8 The Lord God sends the evils; who is there to drive them
away? 9 Fire has gone out from his anger; who is there to quench it?
10 He will flash lightning, and who will not fear? He will thunder, and
who will not shudder? 11 The Lord will threaten, and who will not
be crushed to pieces before his face? 12 The earth and its foundations
quake; the sea heaves up from the deep, and its waves and its fish are
thrown into turmoil before the face of the Lord and the glory of his
might. 13 For strong is his right hand that bends the bow; sharp are
the arrows that he shoots, and once they begin to be sent to the ends
of the earth, they will not miss. 14 See, the evils are sent forth, and will
not turn back until they come upon the earth. 15 The fire has been lit,
and it will not go out until it has consumed the foundations of the
earth. 16 As an arrow shot by a mighty archer does not come back, so
the evils that are sent upon the earth will not turn back. 17 Woe is me,
woe is me! Who will rescue me in those days?
18 The beginning of sorrows, and much groaning; the beginning of
famine, and many deaths; the beginning of wars, and the powers
will be afraid; the beginning of evils, and all will tremble! 19 What
shall I do in these things, when the evils come? 20 Look: hunger and
pestilence, affliction and distress have been dispatched as whips to
bring correction; 21 yet for all these things they will not turn from
their iniquities, nor ever keep the scourges in mind. 22 See, food will
be so cheap on the earth that people will suppose peace is assured;
and then evils will spring up on the earth: sword, famine, and great
confusion. 23 For most of earth's dwellers will perish by famine; and
the sword will destroy the rest, who survive the famine. 24 The dead

will be dumped like manure, and no one will comfort them; the earth will be left desolate, and its cities torn down. 25 There will be no one left to till the earth or sow it. 26 The trees will bear fruit, but who will gather it? 27 The grapes will ripen, but who will tread them? For in all places there will be great desolation. 28 Each will yearn just to catch sight of a fellow human, or to hear the sound of someone's voice. 29 For ten will be left out of a city, and two out of the countryside, those who have hidden in the dense thickets and the clefts of the rocks. 30 Just as a few olives, three or four, remain on every tree of an olive grove, 31 or as in a vineyard that has been gathered some clusters are left by those who search the vineyard with care, 32 so in those days a remnant of three or four will escape the ones who comb through their houses sword in hand. 33 The earth will be left desolate, and its fields will grow old;[b] its roads and all its paths will sprout thorns, because no one will travel through it. 34 Virgins will mourn because they have no bridegrooms; women will mourn because they have no husbands; their daughters will mourn because they have no helpers. 35 Their bridegrooms will be destroyed in war, and their husbands will perish of famine.

36 But hear these things and understand them, you servants of the Lord. 37 See, here is the word of the Lord; receive it. Do not put your trust in the gods of whom the Lord speaks.[c] 38 See, the evils are drawing near and do not delay. 39 Just as a woman with child in her ninth month, when her time of delivery approaches, is seized two or three hours before by pangs that encircle her womb, and once the infant comes out there is not an instant's pause, 40 so the evils will not linger in coming forth upon the earth; the world will groan, and pangs will grip it on every side.

41 "Listen to the word, my people: make ready for the fight, and amid the evils live as aliens in the land. 42 Let the seller be like one who flees, and the buyer like one who is about to lose; 43 let the merchant be like one who will get no profit, and the builder like one who will not live in the house; 44 let the sower be like one who will not reap, and the one who prunes the vine like one who will not gather the grapes; 45 let the ones who wed be as though they will beget no offspring, and

the unwed as though bereaved.[d] 46 For this reason those who labor,
labor in vain; 47 for strangers will reap their fruit, seize their goods,
overturn their houses, and take their children captive; for in captivity
and famine they bring forth their children. 48 And those who trade by
robbery, the more they adorn their cities and houses, their property
and their persons, 49 the more I will be angry with them for their sins,
says the Lord. 50 Just as a harlot is jealous of a decent and very good
woman, 51 so righteousness hates iniquity when she adorns herself,
and accuses her to her face, when he comes who will defend the one
who searches out every sin on earth.[e] 52 Therefore do not be like her
or her works; 53 for in a very little while iniquity will be taken away
from the earth, and righteousness will reign over you. 54 Let no sinner
say that he has not sinned; for God will burn coals of fire[f] on the head
of anyone who says, 'I have not sinned before God and his glory.' 55
See, the Lord knows all the works of human beings, their devices,
their thoughts, and their hearts. 56 For he said, 'Let the earth be made,'
and it was made; 'Let heaven be made,' and it was made. 57 At his
word the stars were fixed, and he knows the number of the stars. 58
He explores the abyss and its treasures; he has measured the sea and
everything in it. 59 He has enclosed the sea within the waters, and by
his word he has hung the earth above the waters. 60 He spread out the
heaven like a vault, and founded it upon the waters. 61 He put springs
of water in the desert and pools on mountaintops, to send rivers down
from the high rock to water the earth. 62 He formed the human being,
and put a heart in the midst of the body, and gave him breath, life,
and understanding, 63 and the breath of God Almighty,[g] who made
all things and searches out all hidden things in hidden places of the
earth. 64 He knows your devices and what you plan in your hearts,
when you sin and wish to hide your sins. 65 Therefore the Lord has
thoroughly searched out all your works, and he will put you all to
shame. 66 You will be confounded when your sins come forth before
people, and your iniquities will be the accusers standing against you
on that day. 67 What will you do? Or how will you hide your sins
before God and his angels? 68 See, God is the judge; fear him. Leave

off your sins, and forget your iniquities, never to commit them again; and God will lead you out and deliver you from every tribulation.
69 For see, the burning wrath of a great multitude is kindled against you; they will carry off some of you and feed you what has been sacrificed to idols.[h] 70 And those who consent to them will be held by them in derision and reproach, and trampled underfoot. 71 For in place after place, and in the neighboring cities, there will be a great uprising against those who fear the Lord. 72 They will be like madmen, sparing no one, plundering and laying waste those who still fear the Lord; 73 for they will lay waste and plunder their goods, and drive them out of their houses. 74 Then the testing of my chosen ones will be made plain, like gold tested by fire.
75 "Hear, my beloved ones, says the Lord: see, the days of tribulation are at hand, and I will deliver you from them. 76 Do not fear or doubt, for God is your guide. 77 You who keep my commandments and precepts, says the Lord God, do not let your sins weigh you down, or your iniquities lift themselves up over you.[i] 78 Woe to any held fast in the grip of their sins and smothered under their iniquities, like a field overgrown with brush whose path lies hidden under thorns, so that no one passes along it; it is closed off and handed over for the fire to devour."

Notes

- a (16:1) Syria, the Greek and Latin name of the land north of Israel (Hebrew Aram); the name is probably shortened from "Assyria."
- b (16:33) Latin inveterabunt, "will grow old," that is, lie fallow and go wild.
- c (16:37) Latin ne diis credatis, "do not believe the gods," perhaps a corruption; the sense may be "do not disbelieve what the Lord says."
- d (16:45) Compare 1 Corinthians 7:29–31.
- e (16:51) The Latin of this verse is obscure.
- f (16:54) Compare Psalm 140:10; Proverbs 25:22.
- g (16:63) Latin spiramen, "breath," recalling Genesis 2:7.
- h (16:69) The persecution described in verses 69–74 seems to be of Christians compelled to eat food sacrificed to idols, as under the emperor Decius (AD 249–251), though the date is uncertain. Compare Acts 15:29; Revelation 2:14, 20.
- i (16:77) The Latin of this verse is broken; the rendering follows the sense.

Prayer of Manasseh

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

The Prayer of Manasseh

1 O Lord Almighty, who are in heaven,[b] God of our fathers, of
Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and of their righteous seed, 2 you who
made the heaven and the earth with all their array,[c] 3 who fettered
the sea by the word of your command, who shut up the abyss and
sealed it with your fearful and glorious name, 4 before whom all
things shudder and tremble at the presence of your power; 5 for the
magnificence of your glory cannot be endured, and the anger of
your threatening against sinners cannot be withstood; 6 but beyond
measure and beyond tracing out is the mercy of your promise,[d] 7 for
you are the Lord Most High, tender in compassion, slow to anger and
abounding in mercy, and you relent over the evils of mankind.[e]
8 But you, Lord, God of the upright, did not set repentance for the
upright—for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, who never offended you; you
have set repentance aside for me, a sinner. 9 For my sins outnumber
the grains of sand along the sea; my lawless acts have piled up,[f] and I
am unfit to look up and see the heights of heaven, so great is the mass
of my wrongs. 10 I am bent down by many a chain of iron, so that I
cannot lift up my head because of my sins,[g] and there is no relief for
me; because I stirred up your fury and did the thing that is evil before
you, setting up abominations and heaping up offenses.[h]
11 And now I bend the knee of my heart, begging for the kindness that
comes from you. 12 I have sinned, O Lord, I have sinned, and I myself
know my lawless deeds. 13 I ask and beg of you: release me, O Lord,
release me! Do not destroy me together with my lawless deeds, nor
be angry with me forever and store up evils for me, nor condemn me
to the lowest parts of the earth. For you, O Lord, are the God of those
who repent, 14 and in me you will display your goodness; for though

I am unworthy, you will save me after the greatness of your mercy, [15] and I will sing your praise without ceasing through every day of my life. For the whole army of heaven praises you, and the glory belongs to you through all ages. Amen.

Notes

- a (1:0) Greek Proseuchē Manassē, "Prayer of Manasseh." In Codex Alexandrinus the title is "Prayer of Manasseh," and the Latin Vulgate appendix has "Prayer of Manasseh, king of Judah, when he was held captive in Babylon." The prayer is set at the moment described in 2 Chronicles 33:11–13, when the Assyrians took King Manasseh in chains to Babylon and he humbled himself and prayed; 2 Chronicles 33:18–19 says his prayer was recorded in the annals of the kings of Israel and of the seers. Manasseh means "causing to forget" (Genesis 41:51). He reigned about 697–642 BC.
- b (1:1) Greek Kyrie pantokratōr epourānie. Greek Kyrios, "Lord," is the word the Septuagint uses for the divine name YHWH; pantokratōr, "Almighty," is its usual rendering of YHWH Tseva'ot, "Yahweh of Armies."
- c (1:2) Greek kosmos, "order, ornament," here the array of heaven and earth (compare Genesis 2:1, where the Septuagint uses the same word).
- d (1:6) The Latin and the Apostolic Constitutions (2.22) are reported to add a sentence at this point that is not in Codex Alexandrinus. In it the speaker tells the Lord that, in the greatness of his goodness, he has promised repentance and forgiveness to people who have sinned against him, and that in his abundant compassion he has set repentance as the way for sinners to be saved. Some later Greek copies reportedly have it as well.
- e (1:7) Compare Joel 2:13 and Jonah 4:2. "Relent over the evils" means to turn from bringing the punishment that human wickedness deserves.
- f (1:9) The Latin and other witnesses reportedly repeat the phrase, with "O Lord": "my lawless deeds have multiplied, O Lord, my lawless deeds have multiplied."
- g (1:10) Greek eis to ananeusai me, literally "so as to throw back my head," an obscure phrase; it is usually understood as "so that I cannot lift up my head," and the Latin is reported to read "so that I cannot lift up my head."
- h (1:10) The Latin reportedly adds "I did not do your will, and I did not keep your commandments." "Abominations" are idols (2 Chronicles 33:3–7).

Psalm 151

Apocrypha

Chapter 1

This psalm was written by David's own hand, and it is outside the number, when he fought Goliath in single combat.

1 I was the least among my brothers, the youngest in my father's
house; I tended my father's flock.[d] 2 My hands made an instrument,
my fingers fitted together a harp.[e] 3 And who will tell my lord?[f] The
Lord himself, he himself gives ear. 4 He himself sent his messenger[g]
and took me from my father's sheep, and anointed me with the oil of
his anointing. 5 My brothers were handsome and great, yet the Lord
took no delight in them.[h] 6 I went forth to encounter the foreigner,[i]
and he called down curses on me by his idols. 7 But I drew the sword
from his side and cut off his head, and I took away disgrace from the
sons of Israel.[j]

Notes

- a (1:0) Greek idiographos eis Dauid, "written with his own hand, belonging to David"; the phrase may also mean "of David's own, unique," that is, a psalm peculiar to David. David means "beloved."
- b (1:0) That is, outside the numbered collection of 150 psalms. In Swete's edition the superscription is printed with the psalm after Psalm 150. In some Greek manuscripts (and in the Syriac, as reported) the title differs.
- c (1:0) Goliath of Gath, the Philistine champion of 1 Samuel 17. The name's meaning is uncertain.
- d (1:1) Compare 1 Samuel 16:11 and 17:14–15. Jesse's youngest son was keeping the sheep when Samuel came to anoint a king.
- e (1:2) Greek organon, "instrument," perhaps a pipe or flute; psaltērion, a stringed instrument. The Hebrew Psalm 151A from Cave 11 (see the source note) reportedly names a flute (ʿugav) and a lyre (kinnor). Compare 1 Samuel 16:16–23, where David plays the lyre for Saul.
- f (1:3) Greek tō kyriō mou, "to my lord," probably meaning God (some take it as Samuel or Saul). The Greek of this verse is abrupt; the Hebrew 11QPs-a text is reported to read here a fuller passage in which David says the mountains and

hills do not bear witness for him, but that God sees and hears everything. The Septuagint uses Kyrios, "Lord," for the divine name YHWH.

- g (1:4) Greek angelos, "messenger, angel." In 1 Samuel 16:1–13 it is the prophet Samuel who comes and anoints David; the Hebrew Psalm 151A is reported to name Samuel here.
- h (1:5) Compare 1 Samuel 16:6–10: "Yahweh does not see as a man sees."
- i (1:6) Greek allophylos, "one of another race," the Septuagint's usual word for a Philistine (1 Samuel 17:10, 23, etc.).
- j (1:7) Compare 1 Samuel 17:43–51. The Hebrew Psalm 151B, preserved only in its opening lines in 11QPs-a, is reported to begin "At the beginning of David's power, after the prophet of God had anointed him," and then to break off as it speaks of the Philistine; the Greek verses 6–7 correspond to this second psalm.

Matthew

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 The record of the origins[a] of Jesus the Messiah,[b] the son of David,
the son of Abraham.
2 Abraham was father to Isaac, Isaac father to Jacob, and Jacob father
to Judah and his brothers.[c] 3 Judah was father to Perez and Zerah by
Tamar, Perez father to Hezron, and Hezron father to Ram.[d] 4 Ram was
father to Amminadab, Amminadab father to Nahshon, and Nahshon
father to Salmon. 5 Salmon was father to Boaz by Rahab, Boaz father
to Obed by Ruth, and Obed father to Jesse. 6 Jesse was father to David
the king. David was father to Solomon by the woman who had been
Uriah's wife. 7 Solomon was father to Rehoboam, Rehoboam father
to Abijah, and Abijah father to Asa.[e] 8 Asa was father to Jehoshaphat,
Jehoshaphat father to Joram, and Joram father to Uzziah.[f] 9 Uzziah
was father to Jotham, Jotham father to Ahaz, and Ahaz father to
Hezekiah. 10 Hezekiah was father to Manasseh, Manasseh father to
Amon,[g] and Amon father to Josiah. 11 Josiah was father to Jechoniah[h]
and his brothers in the time of the exile to Babylon.
12 After the exile to Babylon, Jechoniah was father to Shealtiel, and
Shealtiel father to Zerubbabel. 13 Zerubbabel was father to Abiud,
Abiud father to Eliakim, and Eliakim father to Azor. 14 Azor was father
to Zadok, Zadok father to Achim, and Achim father to Eliud. 15 Eliud
was father to Eleazar, Eleazar father to Matthan, and Matthan father
to Jacob. 16 Jacob was father to Joseph the husband of Mary,[i] and from
her was born Jesus, who is called Messiah. 17 So the generations from
Abraham to David were fourteen in all; from David to the exile to
Babylon, fourteen generations; and from the exile to Babylon to the
Messiah, fourteen generations.[j]
18 The birth of Jesus the Messiah happened like this. His mother Mary
had been promised in marriage to Joseph, and before they came

together it became evident that she was carrying a child from the Holy Spirit. 19 Joseph her husband was a just man, and because he did not wish to make a public example of her, he made up his mind to release her from the marriage in secret.[k] 20 But while he was weighing these things, an angel of the Lord[l] appeared to him in a dream and said, "Joseph, son of David, have no fear about taking Mary to be your wife, because what has been conceived in her comes from the Holy Spirit. 21 She will bear a son. You are to name him Jesus, since he is the one who will rescue his people from their sins."[m]
22 All of this took place so that the word spoken by the Lord through the prophet would be fulfilled: 23 "Look, the virgin will become pregnant and will give birth to a son, and they will call his name Emmanuel,"[n] a name that means, when translated, "God with us." 24 When Joseph awoke from his sleep, he did what the angel of the Lord had directed him to do, and took his wife into his home. 25 Yet he did not have relations with her[o] until she had given birth to a son; and he gave him the name Jesus.

Notes

- a (1:1) The record of the origins: Greek *biblos geneseōs*, "book of the genesis," the phrase used in the Greek Old Testament at Gen 2:4 and 5:1. It may introduce the genealogy alone (1:1–17) or the whole account of Jesus' beginnings.
- b (1:1) Jesus the Messiah: *Jesus* is the Greek form of the Hebrew *Yeshua* (*Yehoshua*, Joshua), "Yahweh saves" (see 1:21). *Messiah* translates Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," the equivalent of Hebrew *mashiach*. In this translation *Christos* is rendered "Messiah" where it functions as a title, as it usually does in the Gospels, and "Christ" where it has become part of Jesus' name.
- c (1:2) The meanings of the Old Testament names in this genealogy are given in the notes at their first appearance in the Old Testament. Compare the genealogies in Ruth 4:18–22 and 1 Chr 1–3.
- d (1:3) Ram: Greek *Aram*, the Greek Old Testament's spelling of Hebrew *Ram* (Ruth 4:19; 1 Chr 2:9–10). Likewise *Nahshon* (Greek *Naassōn*), *Hezron* (*Esrōm*), *Uzziah* (*Ozias*) and others are given in their Old Testament forms.
- e (1:7) Asa: the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus, Vaticanus), reads *Asaph*, the name of the psalmist; later manuscripts read *Asa*, the name of the king (1 Kgs 15:8). *Asaph* may be the evangelist's own spelling or an early slip; the king is clearly meant. Scholarly review recommended.

- f (1:8) Joram ... Uzziah: three kings, Ahaziah, Joash and Amaziah, stand between Joram and Uzziah in 1 Chr 3:11–12; the genealogy omits them, probably to arrive at three sets of fourteen (1:17). Uzziah is also called Azariah (2 Kgs 15:1).
- g (1:10) Amon: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, reads *Amos*; later manuscripts read *Amon*, the name of the king (2 Kgs 21:18). As in verse 7, the king is meant.
- h (1:11) Jechoniah: also called Jehoiachin (2 Kgs 24:6–15). His father Jehoiakim is not named; Jechoniah was Josiah's grandson (1 Chr 3:15–16).
- i (1:16) Joseph ... Mary: *Joseph* means "may he add" (Gen 30:24). *Mary* (Greek *Maria* or *Mariam*) is the Hebrew name *Miriam* (Exod 15:20); its meaning is uncertain.
- j (1:17) Fourteen generations: the three groups are arranged deliberately. It has been suggested that fourteen is the numerical value of the name *David* in Hebrew (D = 4, W = 6, D = 4); this is reported, not certain.
- k (1:19) Release her from the marriage in secret: Jewish betrothal was a binding legal commitment, already called marriage (Joseph is her "husband"), and could be ended only by divorce. Joseph planned a private divorce rather than a public accusation.
- l (1:20) An angel of the Lord: in the Old Testament, "the angel of Yahweh." The Greek *kyrios* ("Lord") here stands for the divine name, as also in 1:22, 24 and 2:13, 15, 19.
- m (1:21) Jesus ... save: the name *Jesus* (*Yeshua*) means "Yahweh saves"; the angel's words play on its meaning.
- n (1:23) Isa 7:14, quoted in the wording of the Greek Old Testament, which has *parthenos*, "virgin"; the Hebrew has *ʿalmah*, "young woman." *Emmanuel* (Hebrew *ʿImmanu ʾEl*) means "God is with us" (Isa 8:8, 10).
- o (1:25) Did not have relations with her: literally "did not know her," the biblical idiom for sexual union.

Chapter 2

1 Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem[a] of Judea in the days of
Herod the king,[b] there came to Jerusalem magi[c] from the regions of
the east, 2 They kept asking, "Where is the one born to be king of the
Jews? We watched his star rise[d] and have come here to bow down
to him." 3 When King Herod heard this he was deeply troubled, and
all Jerusalem with him. 4 He called together all the chief priests and
scribes[e] of the people and pressed them to tell him where the Messiah
was to be born. 5 They told him, "In Bethlehem of Judea, for this is
what the prophet wrote: 6 'And you, Bethlehem, in Judah's land, are in

no way the least among Judah's leading towns; out of you will come
forth a ruler, one who will be shepherd of my people Israel.' "[f]
7 Then Herod summoned the magi in secret and learned from them
exactly when the star had appeared. 8 He sent them to Bethlehem with
these words: "Search carefully for the child. When you find him, bring
me word, so that I too can go and bow down to him." 9 They heard
what the king said and went on their way. The star they had seen
rising went before them and finally stopped above the place where
the child was. 10 When they saw the star, their joy knew no bounds. 11
Going into the house, they saw the child with Mary his mother, and
they fell down and paid him homage. Then they opened their treasure
chests and presented him with gifts: gold, frankincense, and myrrh.[g]
12 Then, warned in a dream not to return to Herod, they went back to
their own land by another route.
13 After they had left, an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a
dream. "Get up!" he said. "Take the child and his mother and flee to
Egypt, and stay put until I give you word. Herod is about to search
for the child so that he can kill him." 14 So Joseph got up, took the
child and his mother by night, and withdrew to Egypt. 15 He remained
there until Herod died. This was to fulfill what the Lord had spoken
through the prophet: "Out of Egypt I called my son."[h]
16 Herod, realizing that the magi had made a fool of him, was furious.
He gave orders to put to death every boy in Bethlehem and all its
surrounding district who was two years of age or younger, reckoning
from the time he had carefully learned from the magi. 17 Then what
had been spoken through Jeremiah the prophet was fulfilled: 18 "A
voice was heard in Ramah, weeping and loud lament: Rachel weeping
for her children; and she would not be comforted, because they are
no more."[i]
19 But when Herod had died, an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream
to Joseph in Egypt 20 and said, "Get up, take the child and his mother,
and go to the land of Israel, because those who sought the child's life
are dead." 21 So he rose, took the child and his mother with him, and
returned to the land of Israel. 22 Yet when he learned that Archelaus[j]
had succeeded his father Herod as ruler of Judea, he was afraid to go

back there. A dream warned him, and he went off to the district of Galilee[k] 23 and went and settled in a town called Nazareth.[l] This was to fulfill what had been spoken through the prophets: "He will be called a Nazarene."

Notes

- a (2:1) Bethlehem: "house of bread," the town of David, about 6 miles (10 km) south of Jerusalem.
- b (2:1) Herod the king: Herod the Great, appointed king of Judea by the Roman Senate, who reigned 37–4 BC. Jesus was therefore born before 4 BC. The name *Herod* probably means "heroic."
- c (2:1) Magi: Greek *magoi*, originally a Persian priestly class; by this period the word was used for experts in astrology and the interpretation of dreams. The text does not call them kings or give their number.
- d (2:2) When it rose: or "in the east." The Greek *en tē anatolē* can mean either; here and in 2:9 it probably refers to the star's rising.
- e (2:4) Scribes: experts in the Law of Moses who taught and interpreted it.
- f (2:6) Mic 5:2 (5:1 in Hebrew), freely combined with 2 Sam 5:2. Where Micah has "who are small among the clans of Judah," the quotation reads "by no means least."
- g (2:11) Gold, frankincense, and myrrh: costly gifts. Frankincense is a fragrant resin burned as incense; myrrh is an aromatic resin used in perfume and in burial (John 19:39). Compare Isa 60:6; Ps 72:10–11.
- h (2:15) Hos 11:1, translated from the Hebrew; the Greek Old Testament reads "his children." In Hosea the "son" is Israel, brought out of Egypt in the exodus.
- i (2:18) Jer 31:15 (38:15 in the Greek Old Testament). Ramah lay about 5 miles (8 km) north of Jerusalem, near the traditional tomb of Rachel; Jeremiah pictures Rachel, the mother of Joseph and Benjamin, mourning the exiles.
- j (2:22) Archelaus: son of Herod the Great, who ruled Judea, Samaria and Idumea from 4 BC until Rome deposed him for brutality in AD 6.
- k (2:22) Galilee: from Hebrew *galil*, "circle" or "district," the northern region of the land west of the Sea of Galilee, then ruled by Herod Antipas.
- l (2:23) Nazareth … Nazarene: Nazareth, a small village in the hills of lower Galilee, is not mentioned in the Old Testament, and no prophetic text contains the words quoted. Matthew may be playing on Hebrew *netser*, "branch," the messianic shoot of Isa 11:1, or on the Nazirite of Judg 13:5, 7; he cites "the prophets" in general. Scholarly review recommended.

Chapter 3

1 In those days John the Baptist[a] came and began to preach in the Judean wilderness, 2 "Turn your lives around,[b] for the kingdom of heaven[c] has come near." 3 He is the one of whom Isaiah the prophet

spoke when he said, “A voice of one calling out in the wilderness:
‘Make ready the way of the Lord, make his paths straight.’ ”[d] 4 John
himself wore clothing made of camel’s hair with a leather belt around
his waist, and his food was locusts and wild honey.[e] 5 Then Jerusalem
and all Judea and the whole region around the Jordan went out to
him, 6 and confessing their sins, they were baptized by him in the
Jordan River.[f]
7 But seeing many Pharisees and Sadducees[g] coming out for his
baptism, he said to them, “Offspring of vipers! Who warned you to
run from the wrath that is on its way? 8 Then produce fruit that fits
with repentance. 9 And do not suppose you can say among yourselves,
‘Abraham is our father,’ for I tell you that God can raise up children
for Abraham out of these stones. 10 Already the ax is lying at the root
of the trees; every tree, then, that fails to bear good fruit is chopped
down and tossed into the fire.
11 “I baptize you with water, calling you to repentance. But the one
who follows me is more powerful than I am, and I am not worthy
to carry his sandals. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and
with fire. 12 His winnowing fork is in his hand, and he will clear his
threshing floor completely; his wheat he will gather into the barn,
but the chaff he will burn up in a fire that cannot be put out.”
13 Then Jesus arrived from Galilee at the Jordan to be baptized by John.
14 John tried to prevent him. “I am the one who needs baptism from
you,” he said, “and yet you are coming to me?” 15 Jesus answered him,
“Let it be so for now. It is right for us in this way to carry out all
that God requires.”[h] Then John consented. 16 And as soon as Jesus had
been baptized, he came up out of the water, and at that moment the
heavens were opened,[i] and he saw the Spirit of God descending like
a dove and coming upon him. 17 And a voice out of the heavens said,
“This is my Son, the one I love; with him I am well pleased.”[j]

Notes

- a (3:1) John the Baptist: *John* is the Greek form of Hebrew *Yohanan*, “Yahweh has been gracious.” *The Baptist* (literally “the one who immerses”) is a title describing his ministry.

- b (3:2) Turn your lives around: Greek *metanoeite*, traditionally “repent,” a call to a complete change of mind and direction. The noun *metanoia* in 3:8, 11 is rendered “repentance.”
- c (3:2) The kingdom of heaven: Matthew’s usual phrase for “the kingdom of God” (the expression found in Mark and Luke), following the Jewish custom of speaking reverently of God by referring to heaven. It means God’s rule as king.
- d (3:3) Isa 40:3, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh, and “make his paths straight” reads “make straight in the desert a highway for our God.” The Hebrew can also be punctuated, “A voice is calling: In the wilderness prepare …”
- e (3:4) Clothing of camel’s hair … leather belt: the dress of Elijah (2 Kgs 1:8; compare Mal 4:5). Locusts were permitted food under the Law (Lev 11:22).
- f (3:6) Jordan River: from Hebrew *Yarden*, probably “the one that goes down.”
- g (3:7) Pharisees and Sadducees: the Pharisees (probably “separated ones”) were a lay movement devoted to strict observance of the Law and its traditions; the Sadducees (probably named after Zadok, the high priest under David and Solomon) were a priestly aristocracy who accepted only the written Law and denied the resurrection (22:23).
- h (3:15) To carry out all that God requires: literally “to fulfill all righteousness.”
- i (3:16) The heavens were opened: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks “to him” after “opened,” which most later manuscripts include.
- j (3:17) This is my Son … well pleased: compare Ps 2:7; Isa 42:1; Gen 22:2. *The one I love*: or “my beloved,” “my only Son.”

Chapter 4

1 Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tested[a]
by the devil.[b] 2 After going without food for forty days and forty
nights, he was famished. 3 The tempter came to him and said, “Since
you are the Son of God, order these stones to turn into loaves of
bread.” 4 But he answered, “Scripture says, ‘Not by bread alone will
a person live, but by every word that goes out from the mouth of
God.’ ”[c]

5 Then the devil brought him to the holy city and set him on the
topmost point[d] of the temple. 6 “If you are the Son of God,” he said,
“throw yourself down. For it is written: ‘He will give his angels orders
about you,’ and ‘They will hold you up in their hands, so that your
foot will not hit a stone.’ ”[e] 7 Jesus told him, “It is also written, ‘You
must not test the Lord your God.’ ”[f]

8 Once more the devil took him up to an exceedingly high mountain
and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor,
9 "I will give you all of this," he said, "if you fall down and worship
me." 10 Then Jesus answered him, "Away with you, Satan![g] For it is
written, 'The Lord your God you shall worship, and him alone you
shall serve.' "[h] 11 Then the devil let him alone, and angels came and
attended to him.
12 When Jesus heard that John had been handed over,[i] he withdrew
into Galilee. 13 He left Nazareth and settled in Capernaum,[j] the lake-
side town in the districts of Zebulun and Naphtali, 14 This happened
to fulfill what the prophet Isaiah had said: 15 "Land of Zebulun, land
of Naphtali, the way of the sea, beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the
Gentiles:[k] 16 the people sitting in darkness have seen a great light,
and on those sitting in the region and shadow of death a light has
dawned."[l] 17 From then on Jesus began to preach and to say, "Turn
your lives around, for the kingdom of heaven has come near."
18 As he was walking along beside the Sea of Galilee, he saw two
brothers, Simon, who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother,[m] casting
a net into the lake, for they were fishermen. 19 He said to them, "Come,
follow me, and I will make you fishers of people." 20 At once they left
their nets behind and followed him. 21 Going on from there, he saw
two other brothers, James the son of Zebedee and John his brother,[n] in
the boat with their father Zebedee, mending their nets; and he called
them. 22 At once they left the boat and their father and followed him.
23 Jesus went about all over Galilee, teaching in their synagogues,[o]
proclaiming the good news[p] of the kingdom, and healing every dis-
ease and every ailment among the people. 24 Word about him spread
through all Syria, and people brought to him all who were ill, those
in the grip of various diseases and pains, those under the power of
demons, epileptics,[q] and the paralyzed; and he healed them. 25 Large
crowds followed him from Galilee, the Ten Towns,[r] Jerusalem, Judea,
and the region across the Jordan.

Notes

- a (4:1) Tested: Greek *peirazō* can mean "test" or "tempt."

- b (4:1) The devil: Greek *diabolos*, “slanderer,” the Greek Old Testament’s word for Hebrew *satan*.
- c (4:4) Deut 8:3. The forty days recall Israel’s forty years in the wilderness and Moses’ forty days on the mountain (Exod 34:28; Deut 9:9).
- d (4:5) Highest point: Greek *pterygion*, “little wing,” perhaps a corner of the temple’s outer wall high above the Kidron Valley. The exact location is uncertain.
- e (4:6) Ps 91:11–12 (90:11–12 in the Greek Old Testament).
- f (4:7) Deut 6:16. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord your God” is “Yahweh your God,” as also in 4:10.
- g (4:10) Satan: Hebrew for “adversary” or “accuser.” Some later manuscripts add “Get behind me” (as in 16:23); the Westcott–Hort text lacks it.
- h (4:10) Deut 6:13. The Hebrew has “You shall fear Yahweh your God and serve him”; Jesus’ wording follows the Greek Old Testament with “worship” and “alone.”
- i (4:12) Handed over: that is, arrested and put in prison (see 14:3–4).
- j (4:13) Capernaum: Greek form of Hebrew *Kefar Nahum*, “village of Nahum,” a town on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee.
- k (4:15) Galilee of the nations: or “of the Gentiles”; the Greek *ethnē* means non-Jewish peoples.
- l (4:16) Isa 9:1–2 (8:23–9:1 in Hebrew), quoted freely.
- m (4:18) Simon … Peter … Andrew: *Simon* is the Greek form of Hebrew *Shimʿon* (Simeon), “one who hears” (Gen 29:33). *Peter*, Greek *Petros*, means “rock” (see 16:18). *Andrew* is a Greek name meaning “manly.”
- n (4:21) James … John: *James* is the English form of the Greek *Iakōbos*, that is, *Jacob* (“heel-grabber” or “he supplants,” Gen 25:26). *Zebedee* is from Hebrew *Zavdi*, “my gift” or “gift of Yahweh.”
- o (4:23) Synagogues: Greek *synagōgē*, “gathering,” the local Jewish assembly for prayer and the reading and teaching of Scripture, and the building where it met.
- p (4:23) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally “gospel.”
- q (4:24) Epileptics: literally “moonstruck,” a term that reflected an ancient belief that seizures were caused by the moon.
- r (4:25) The Ten Towns: Greek *Dekapolis*, a league of largely Gentile cities, most of them east of the Jordan.

Chapter 5

1 Seeing the crowds, Jesus climbed the mountain. He sat down, and his
disciples gathered around him. 2 and he began to teach them. He said:
3 “Blessed[a] are those who are poor in spirit, since theirs is the kingdom
of heaven. 4 Blessed are those who grieve, for they will be comforted. 5
Blessed are the gentle, for the earth will be their inheritance.[b] 6 Blessed
are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be

filled to the full. 7 Blessed are those who show mercy, for mercy will
be shown to them. 8 Blessed are the pure in heart, since it is they who
will see God. 9 Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be named
children of God. 10 Blessed are those who are persecuted for doing
what is right, because the kingdom of heaven belongs to them.
11 "You are blessed when people insult you, harass you, and tell all
kinds of lies about you because of me. 12 Rejoice and be glad, for great
is your reward in heaven; that is how they hounded the prophets who
came before you.
13 "You are the salt of the earth. But if salt goes flat,[c] how will its
saltiness be restored? It is then good for nothing except to be thrown
out and walked on by people. 14 You are the light of the world. A town
that sits on a hilltop cannot stay hidden. 15 Nor does anyone light a
lamp and set it under a basket;[d] they put it on the lampstand, and it
gives light to everyone in the house. 16 In the same way, your light
must shine in front of others, so that they see the good you do and
praise your Father in heaven.
17 "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets. I
have come not to abolish them but to fulfill them. 18 Amen,[e] I tell you,
until heaven and earth pass away, not one iota, not one tiny stroke,[f]
will pass away from the Law until everything has taken place. 19 So
anyone who loosens even one of the least of these commandments,
and teaches people to do likewise, will be named least in the kingdom
of heaven; but anyone who obeys them and teaches them will be
named great in the kingdom of heaven. 20 For I tell you that unless
your righteousness goes far beyond that of the scribes and Pharisees,
you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.
21 "You have heard that it was said to the people of long ago, 'You shall
not murder,'[g] and 'Whoever murders will be liable to judgment.' 22 But
I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother[h] will be
liable to judgment; whoever says to his brother, 'Raca,'[i] will be liable
to the high council;[j] and whoever says, 'You fool,' will be liable to the
fire of Gehenna.[k] 23 So if you are offering your gift at the altar and
there you recall that your brother has something against you, 24 leave
your gift right there in front of the altar and go. First be reconciled

with your brother, and then come back and offer your gift. 25 Come to
terms quickly with your opponent at law while you are still on the
way with him, or your opponent may hand you over to the judge,
and the judge to the officer, and you will be put in prison. 26 Amen,
I tell you, you will not get out of there until you have paid back the
last cent.[l]
27 "You have heard that it was said, 'You shall not commit adultery.'[m]
28 But I say to you that anyone who looks at a woman with desire for
her has already committed adultery with her in his heart. 29 If your
right eye trips you up,[n] gouge it out and fling it away. Better for you
that one of your members be lost than that your entire body be cast
into Gehenna. 30 And if your right hand trips you up, cut it off and
fling it away. Better for you that one of your members be lost than
that your entire body go off into Gehenna.
31 "It has been said too, 'Anyone who sends away his wife is to
hand her a written notice of divorce.'[o] 32 But I tell you, anyone who
sends away his wife, other than for sexual immorality,[p] causes her
to become an adulteress, and anyone who marries a woman so sent
away commits adultery.
33 "Again, you have heard that it was said to the people of long ago,
'You shall not break your oath, but you shall carry out the oaths
you have sworn to the Lord.'[q] 34 But I say to you, take no oath at
all, whether by heaven, because it is God's throne, 35 or by the earth,
because it is the footstool for his feet, or by Jerusalem, because it is
the city of the great King.[r] 36 Nor should you swear by your head, for
you cannot make one single hair white or black. 37 Let your speech be
'Yes, yes' or 'No, no'; anything beyond that comes from the evil one.[s]
38 "You have heard that it was said, 'An eye for an eye and a tooth
for a tooth.'[t] 39 But I tell you: do not resist someone who is evil. If
anyone slaps you on the right cheek, offer the other cheek too. 40 And
if someone wants to sue you and take your shirt,[u] let him have your
cloak as well. 41 If anyone forces you to carry a load for one mile,[v]
carry it for two. 42 Give to the one who asks you, and do not turn your
back on the one who would borrow from you.

43 “You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall love your neighbor and
hate your enemy.’[w] 44 But I say to you, love your enemies and pray
for those who persecute you,[x] 45 so that you may become sons of your
Father in heaven; for he makes his sun rise on the evil and the good,
and sends rain on those who do right and those who do wrong. 46 For
if you love those who love you, what reward will you have? Do not
even the tax collectors[y] do the same? 47 And if you greet only your
brothers, what are you doing that is out of the ordinary? Do not even
the Gentiles do the same? 48 You, then, are to be perfect,[z] just as your
heavenly Father is perfect.

Notes

- a (5:3) Blessed: Greek *makarios*, “happy,” “fortunate,” in the sense of being favored by God; also in verses 4–11.
- b (5:5) Ps 37:11. *Earth* may also be translated “land.”
- c (5:13) Goes flat: literally “becomes foolish,” that is, loses its taste. Ancient salt from the Dead Sea region was mixed with other minerals and could lose its savor.
- d (5:15) Basket: Greek *modios*, a container holding about 9 quarts (8.75 liters) of dry goods, used as a measuring bucket.
- e (5:18) Amen: a Hebrew word meaning “surely,” “so be it.” Jesus uses it uniquely to introduce his own solemn statements, rather than to confirm someone else’s words. Traditionally translated “Truly” or “Verily.”
- f (5:18) Iota … stroke: the iota is the smallest Greek letter (corresponding to Hebrew *yod*); the “stroke” (Greek *keraia*, “little horn”) is a small mark that distinguishes one Hebrew letter from another.
- g (5:21) Exod 20:13; Deut 5:17.
- h (5:22) Angry with his brother: many later manuscripts add “without cause”; the earliest witnesses, including P64/67 (reported), Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lack it, and the Westcott–Hort text omits it. *Brother* here means a fellow member of the community, man or woman.
- i (5:22) Raca: an Aramaic term of contempt, probably “empty-head.”
- j (5:22) High council: Greek *synedrion*, the Sanhedrin, the supreme Jewish council in Jerusalem.
- k (5:22) Gehenna: the Greek form of Hebrew *Ge Hinnom*, “Valley of Hinnom,” south of Jerusalem, once a site of child sacrifice (Jer 7:31) and later a symbol of final judgment. Traditionally translated “hell.”
- l (5:26) Last cent: Greek *kodrantēs* (Latin *quadrans*), the smallest Roman copper coin, worth one sixty-fourth of a denarius (a day’s wage).
- m (5:27) Exod 20:14; Deut 5:18.
- n (5:29) Causes you to fall: Greek *skandalizō*, to cause someone to stumble into sin; also in verse 30.

- o (5:31) Deut 24:1–4.
- p (5:32) Sexual immorality: Greek *porneia*, a broad term for illicit sexual conduct.
- q (5:33) Lev 19:12; Num 30:2; Deut 23:21. In the Old Testament the oath is sworn to Yahweh.
- r (5:35) Isa 66:1; Ps 48:2.
- s (5:37) The evil one: or "evil." The Greek can be masculine ("the evil one," the devil) or neuter ("evil"); also in 5:39 and 6:13.
- t (5:38) Exod 21:24; Lev 24:20; Deut 19:21.
- u (5:40) Shirt ... cloak: the *chitōn* was the long tunic worn next to the skin; the *himation* was the outer garment, which a poor person also used as a blanket at night (Exod 22:26–27).
- v (5:41) One mile: Greek *milion*, the Roman mile of a thousand paces, about 1,620 yards (1.48 km). Roman soldiers could compel civilians to carry their baggage for this distance.
- w (5:43) Lev 19:18. "Hate your enemy" is not found in the Old Testament; it may reflect popular understanding of the command.
- x (5:44) Pray for those who persecute you: later manuscripts expand the verse to read "bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who mistreat you and persecute you" (compare Luke 6:27–28). The Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, has the shorter reading.
- y (5:46) Tax collectors: local Jews who collected tolls and taxes for Rome or for Herod Antipas, widely despised as collaborators and for their dishonesty.
- z (5:48) Perfect: Greek *teleios*, "complete," "whole," "mature"; compare Lev 19:2; Deut 18:13.

Chapter 6

1 "Be careful not to practice your righteousness in front of others in
order to be seen by them; otherwise you have no reward from your
Father in heaven.
2 "So whenever you give to the poor, do not blow a trumpet before
you, as the hypocrites[a] do in the synagogues and in the streets, so as
to win people's praise. Amen, I tell you, they have their reward in full.
3 Rather, when you give alms, keep your left hand unaware of what
your right hand does, 4 so that your almsgiving may stay hidden; and
your Father, who sees in secret, will repay you.[b]
5 "And whenever you pray, do not be like the hypocrites; they love to
stand and pray in the synagogues and on the street corners, so that
people will see them. Amen, I tell you, they have their reward in full.

6 But you, when you pray, enter your private room, shut your door,
and pray to your Father who is unseen; and your Father, who sees in
secret, will repay you.
7 "When you pray, do not babble on and on as the Gentiles do, for
they think that by using a great many words they will get a hearing.
8 So do not be like them, for your Father knows what you need before
you ask him.
9 Pray, then, in this way:
'Our Father, you who are in heaven,
let your name be treated as holy.
10 May your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is done in heaven.
11 Give us today the bread we need for the day ahead;[c]
12 and forgive us our debts,
as we too have forgiven those who are in debt to us;[d]
13 and do not lead us into a time of testing,
but rescue us from the evil one.'[e]
14 For if you forgive others their wrongdoings, your heavenly Father
will forgive you as well;
15 but if you do not forgive people, neither will your Father pardon
your wrongdoings.
16 "And whenever you fast, do not look gloomy like the hypocrites,
for they make their faces unsightly[f] so that people will notice they
are fasting. Amen, I tell you, they have their reward in full. 17 But you,
when you fast, anoint your head and wash your face, 18 so that it will
not be people who notice that you are fasting, but your Father, who
is in secret; and your Father, who sees in secret, will repay you.
19 "Do not pile up for yourselves treasures on earth, where the moth
and rust[g] eat them away and where burglars break in and steal. 20
Instead, pile up treasures for yourselves in heaven, where neither
moth nor rust eats them away, and where burglars do not break in
or steal. 21 For where your treasure is, that is where your heart will
be too.

22 “The lamp of the body is the eye. If your eye is sound,[h] then, your
whole body will be full of light; 23 but if your eye is diseased, your
entire body will be filled with darkness. If, then, the light within you
is darkness, how deep that darkness is!
24 “No one can be a slave to two masters; either he will hate the one
and love the other, or he will be loyal to one and despise the other.
You cannot be a slave both to God and to wealth.[i]
25 “For this reason I tell you: stop worrying about your life, what you
will eat or drink, or about your body, what you will wear. Is life not
worth more than food, and the body more than clothes? 26 Consider
the birds in the sky. They do not plant or harvest or store grain in
barns, yet your heavenly Father feeds them. Do you not count for far
more than they do? 27 And which of you by worrying can add even
eighteen inches[j] to the span of his life? 28 And why are you anxious
about clothing? Study how the wildflowers[k] of the field grow; they
do not toil or spin thread, 29 yet I tell you, not even Solomon in all
his splendor was clothed like one of these. 30 Now if God puts such
clothing on the grass of the field, which blooms today and is thrown
into the oven tomorrow, will he not provide much more for you,
people of weak faith? 31 Do not fret, then, asking, ‘What will there
be to eat?’ or ‘What will there be to drink?’ or ‘What are we going
to wear?’ 32 For the Gentiles are eagerly seeking all these things; and
your heavenly Father knows that you need them all. 33 But seek first
his kingdom[l] and his righteousness, and all these things will be given
to you as well. 34 So do not be anxious about tomorrow, for tomorrow
will have its own anxieties. Each day has trouble enough of its own.

Notes

- a (6:2) Hypocrites: Greek *hypokritai*, “actors,” people who play a part on a stage.
- b (6:4) Will reward you: later manuscripts add “openly,” here and in verses 6 and 18; the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts, lacks it.
- c (6:11) The bread we need for the day ahead: the rare Greek word *epiousios* may mean “for the coming day,” “for today,” or “necessary for existence.” Its meaning is uncertain.
- d (6:12) Debts … in debt to us: sins are pictured as debts owed to God; compare Luke 11:4, “forgive us our sins.”

- e (6:13) The evil one: or “evil.” Later manuscripts add a closing doxology: “For yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever. Amen.” It is absent from the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Bezae) and from the earliest commentators on the prayer, and it is not part of the Westcott–Hort text. It is an early liturgical ending, probably modeled on 1 Chr 29:11–13; a shorter form appears in the Didache (8.2, about AD 100). It is therefore given here and not in the text.
- f (6:16) Unsightly: literally “make their faces disappear,” perhaps by covering them with ashes or by leaving them unwashed.
- g (6:19) Rust: Greek *brōsis*, “eating,” perhaps the corrosion of metal or the gnawing of vermin; also in verse 20.
- h (6:22) Healthy: Greek *haplous*, “single,” “sound,” also “generous.” A “diseased” (literally “evil”) eye in verse 23 was an idiom for a stingy or envious disposition.
- i (6:24) Wealth: Greek *mamōnas*, from Aramaic *mamona*, “wealth,” “property,” traditionally “mammon.”
- j (6:27) Eighteen inches: literally “one cubit,” the length from the elbow to the fingertip, about 18 inches (45 cm). The word for *span of life* (*hēlikia*) can also mean “stature,” but the context concerns length of life; the expression may then mean “a single hour.”
- k (6:28) Wildflowers: Greek *krina*, traditionally “lilies,” probably a general term for the bright wildflowers of Galilee.
- l (6:33) His kingdom: later manuscripts read “the kingdom of God.”

Chapter 7

1 “Do not judge, so that you may not be judged. 2 For the judgment
you pass on others is the judgment that will be passed on you, and
the measure you measure out is the measure you will receive. 3 Why
do you notice the speck in your brother’s eye but never notice the log
in your own eye? 4 How can you say to your brother, ‘Allow me to
take the speck out of your eye,’ while a log sticks out of your own?
5 You hypocrite, first pull the log out of your own eye, and then you
will see well enough to pull the speck from your brother’s eye.
6 “Do not give what is sacred to dogs, and do not toss your pearls
to pigs; they will trample them underfoot, then turn on you and rip
you apart.
7 “Keep asking, and it will be given you; keep seeking, and you will
find; keep knocking, and it will be opened for you. 8 For all who
ask receive; whoever seeks finds; and for whoever knocks, it will be

opened. 9 Is there anyone among you who, if his son asks for bread,
will hand him a stone? 10 Or if he asks for a fish, will hand him a
snake? 11 If you, then, though you are evil, know how to give your
children good gifts, how much more will your Father in heaven give
good things to those who ask him! 12 So in everything, treat others in
the way you want them to treat you; for this sums up the Law and
the Prophets.
13 "Enter through the narrow gate. The gate to destruction is wide and
its road is easy, and many people go in that way. 14 But how narrow[a] is
the gate and how hard is the road that leads to life, and few are those
who find it.
15 "Watch out for false prophets, who come to you in sheep's clothing
but underneath are ravenous wolves. 16 By their fruit you will know
them. Do people pick grapes off thorns, or figs off thistles? 17 Just so,
every healthy tree produces good fruit, but the diseased tree produces
bad fruit. 18 A healthy tree cannot produce bad fruit, nor can a diseased
tree produce good fruit. 19 Any tree that fails to yield good fruit is
cut down and cast into the fire. 20 So it is by their fruit that you will
know them.
21 "It is not all who call me 'Lord, Lord' who will enter the kingdom of
heaven, but the one who carries out the will of my Father in heaven.
22 Many will say to me on that day, 'Lord, Lord, was it not in your
name that we prophesied, in your name that we cast out demons, and
in your name that we did many works of power?' 23 And then I will
tell them plainly, 'I never knew you. Depart from me, you workers of
lawlessness.'[b]
24 "Everyone who hears these words of mine and acts on them is like
a wise man who built his house on rock. 25 The rain came down, the
rivers rose, and the winds blew and battered that house, yet it did not
fall, because its foundation had been laid on the rock. 26 And everyone
who hears these words of mine and does not act on them will be like
a foolish man who built his house on the sand. 27 The rain came down,
the rivers rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house, and
it fell, and great was its downfall."

28 When Jesus had finished these sayings,[c] the crowds were amazed
at his teaching, 29 since he taught them as one with authority, unlike
their scribes.

Notes

- a (7:14) How narrow: some manuscripts read "for narrow." The Westcott–Hort text reads *ti*, "how," with most witnesses.
- b (7:23) Ps 6:8.
- c (7:28) When Jesus had finished these sayings: this formula closes each of the five great blocks of Jesus' teaching in Matthew (7:28; 11:1; 13:53; 19:1; 26:1).

Chapter 8

1 When he came down from the mountain, great crowds followed him.
2 And just then a man with leprosy[a] approached, knelt before him, and
said, "Lord, if you are willing, you have the power to make me clean."
3 Jesus stretched out his hand and touched him, saying, "I am willing;
be made clean." And immediately his leprosy was cleansed away. 4
Then Jesus said to him, "Be sure you tell no one; but go and let the
priest examine you, and bring the offering that Moses commanded,[b]
as evidence to them."
5 When he had entered Capernaum, a centurion[c] came up to him and
pleaded with him, 6 "Lord, my servant boy lies paralyzed in the house,
suffering dreadfully." 7 Jesus answered, "Shall I come and heal him?"[d]
8 The centurion replied, "Lord, I am not worthy to have you come
under my roof. Just say the word, and my servant will be healed. 9 For
I myself am a man placed under authority, with soldiers under me. I
say to one, 'Go,' and he goes, and to another, 'Come,' and he comes,
and to my slave, 'Do this,' and he does it." 10 Jesus was amazed to hear
this and told those who followed him, "Amen, I tell you, in no one
in Israel have I found such faith.[e] 11 I tell you that many will come
from the east and the west and will sit at the table with Abraham,
Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven, 12 while the heirs of the
kingdom[f] will be thrown out into the darkness outside; there people
will weep and grind their teeth." 13 Then Jesus said to the centurion,
"Go home. Because you believed, what you asked for will happen."
And his servant was healed that very hour.

14 Coming into Peter's house, Jesus saw that Peter's wife's mother was
laid up with a fever. 15 He took hold of her hand, and the fever left
her; she rose and began to serve him. 16 When evening came, people
brought to him many who were under the power of demons. He
drove out the spirits with a word and healed all who were sick, 17 This
fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah had said: "He took our weaknesses
on himself and bore our diseases."[g]
18 When Jesus saw the crowd pressing around him, he ordered a
crossing to the far shore. 19 Then a scribe came up and said to him,
"Teacher, I will follow you wherever you are going." 20 Jesus told him,
"Foxes have dens and the birds of the sky have nests, but the Son of
Man[h] has nowhere to rest his head." 21 Another of his disciples said
to him, "Lord, allow me first to go away and bury my father."[i] 22 But
Jesus told him, "Follow me, and let the dead bury their own dead."
23 He got into the boat, and his disciples went with him. 24 Without
warning a violent storm[j] arose on the lake, so that the boat was being
swamped by the waves; but he was sleeping. 25 They came and woke
him, crying, "Lord, save us! We are going to die!" 26 He said to them,
"Why are you so fearful, you people of little faith?" Then he got up
and rebuked the winds and the lake, and there was a great calm. 27
The men were astonished and said, "What sort of man is this, that
even the winds and the lake obey him?"
28 When he reached the other side, the country of the Gadarenes,[k]
two men under the power of demons met him, coming out from the
tombs. They were so violent that no one could travel along that road.
29 All at once they shrieked, "What do you want with us, Son of God?
[l] Have you come here to torment us before the appointed time?" 30
Some distance away a large herd of pigs was feeding. 31 The demons
pleaded with him, "If you drive us out, send us into that herd of pigs."
32 "Go," he told them. They came out and went off into the pigs, and
the entire herd stampeded down the slope into the lake and drowned.
33 The herdsmen fled, went off into the town, and reported everything,
including what had happened to the men who had been demonized.
34 And the entire town came out to meet Jesus; and when they saw
him, they pleaded with him to leave their district.

Notes

- a (8:2) Leprosy: the Greek word covered a range of skin diseases (see Lev 13–14), not only Hansen's disease. Such a person was ritually unclean and excluded from community life.
- b (8:4) Lev 14:2–32.
- c (8:5) Centurion: a Roman officer in command of about a hundred soldiers; this one, stationed in Galilee, was probably serving Herod Antipas and was a Gentile.
- d (8:7) Am I to come and heal him?: or, as a statement, "I will come and heal him." The Greek can be read either way.
- e (8:10) With no one in Israel …: some manuscripts read "not even in Israel have I found such faith." The Westcott–Hort text follows Vaticanus and other early witnesses.
- f (8:12) Heirs of the kingdom: literally "sons of the kingdom," those who would be expected to inherit it.
- g (8:17) Isa 53:4, translated from the Hebrew.
- h (8:20) Son of Man: Jesus' preferred way of referring to himself. In Aramaic the phrase can mean simply "a human being" (compare Ps 8:4; Ezek 2:1), but it also recalls the heavenly figure of Dan 7:13–14.
- i (8:21) Bury my father: this may mean that the man's father had just died, or that he wished to wait until his father died and he had received his inheritance.
- j (8:24) Violent storm: Greek *seismos megas*, literally "a great shaking," the word normally used for an earthquake.
- k (8:28) Gadarenes: the people of Gadara, a city of the Ten Towns about 6 miles (10 km) southeast of the lake. Manuscripts vary: the Westcott–Hort text reads *Gadarenes* with Vaticanus; others read *Gerasenes* (as in Mark 5:1) or *Gergesenes*. Scholarly review recommended.
- l (8:29) Son of God: later manuscripts add "Jesus."

Chapter 9

1 He stepped into a boat, crossed the lake, and came to his own town.[a]
2 And there they brought him a man who was paralyzed, laid on a
stretcher. Seeing their faith, Jesus told the paralyzed man, "Courage,
my son; your sins are forgiven." 3 At this some of the scribes said to
themselves, "This man is blaspheming." 4 Jesus, knowing[b] what they
were thinking, said, "Why do you think evil things in your hearts? 5
Which is easier: to say, 'Your sins are forgiven,' or to say, 'Get up and
walk'? 6 But I want you to know that the Son of Man has authority
on earth to forgive sins." Then he said to the paralyzed man, "Stand
up, pick up your mat, and go to your house." 7 And the man got up

and went off home. 8 The crowds who saw it were struck with awe,[c]
and they glorified God for giving such authority to mortals.
9 Leaving that place, Jesus saw a man called Matthew[d] seated at the
tax collector's booth. "Follow me," he said to him, and Matthew rose
and followed him. 10 Later, as Jesus was reclining at table in the
house,[e] many tax collectors and sinners came and joined Jesus and his
disciples at the meal. 11 Seeing this, the Pharisees said to his disciples,
"Why does your teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?" 12 He
heard them and said, "It is not the healthy who have need of a doctor,
but the sick. 13 Go and find out what this means: 'It is mercy I desire,
and not sacrifice.'[f] For I did not come to call the righteous, but sinners."
14 Then John's disciples came to him and asked, "Why is it that we
and the Pharisees fast often,[g] but your disciples do not fast?" 15 Jesus
answered them, "Can the bridegroom's friends[h] mourn while he is
still with them? But days are coming when the bridegroom will be
taken from them, and then they will fast. 16 Nobody sews a patch of
unshrunk cloth on an old garment; the patch would pull away from
the garment, and a worse tear would result. 17 Nor do people pour new
wine into old wineskins;[i] if they do, the skins split open, the wine
pours out, and the skins are ruined. Instead they pour new wine into
fresh wineskins, and both are kept safe."
18 While he was saying these things to them, a leader[j] came in, knelt
before him, and said, "My daughter has just died; but come and lay
your hand on her, and she will live." 19 So Jesus rose and followed him,
together with his disciples. 20 Then a woman who had suffered from
bleeding for twelve years came up behind him and touched the tassel[k]
of his cloak. 21 She had been telling herself, "If I can just touch his
cloak, I will be healed." 22 Jesus turned, and when he saw her, he said,
"Courage, daughter! Your faith has made you whole." And from that
very hour the woman was whole. 23 When Jesus came into the leader's
house and saw the flute players[l] and the crowd making a commotion,
24 he told them, "Leave; the girl has not died, she is sleeping." They
ridiculed him. 25 But once the crowd had been put outside, he went in
and took her by the hand, and the girl rose up. 26 And the news of this
spread through that whole region.

27 As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed him, crying
out, “Have mercy on us, Son of David!”[m] 28 When he went into the
house, the blind men approached him, and Jesus asked, “Do you
believe I can do this?” “Yes, Lord,” they answered. 29 Then he touched
their eyes and said, “Be it done to you in keeping with your faith.”[n] 30
And their eyes were opened. Jesus gave them a stern warning, “See
that no one learns of this.” 31 But they went out and made him known
throughout that whole district.
32 As they were leaving, some people brought to him a man who could
not speak because of a demon. 33 And when the demon had been
driven out, the mute man spoke. The crowds were amazed and said,
“Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel.” 34 [But the Pharisees
were saying, “It is by the ruler of the demons that he drives out the
demons.”][o]
35 Jesus went around all the towns and villages, teaching in their
synagogues, proclaiming the good news of the kingdom, and healing
every disease and every ailment. 36 Seeing the crowds, he was moved
with compassion for them, because they were worn out and helpless,
like sheep with no shepherd.[p] 37 Then he told his disciples, “The
harvest is great, but the laborers are few. 38 Ask the Lord of the harvest,
then, to send out workers into his harvest.”

Notes

- a (9:1) His own town: Capernaum (4:13).
- b (9:4) Knowing: many manuscripts read “seeing,” which the Westcott–Hort text places in the margin.
- c (9:8) Filled with awe: literally “they were afraid.” Later manuscripts read “they marveled.”
- d (9:9) Matthew: from Hebrew *Mattithyah*, “gift of Yahweh.” In Mark 2:14 and Luke 5:27 the tax collector is called Levi; the Gospel bearing his name was attributed to him from the second century.
- e (9:10) In the house: probably Matthew’s house (compare Luke 5:29), though the Greek may mean Jesus’ own house. At formal meals guests reclined on couches, leaning on the left elbow.
- f (9:13) Hos 6:6, quoted again in 12:7.
- g (9:14) Fast often: the Westcott–Hort text, with the first hand of Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks “often,” which it places in the margin; most manuscripts include it.

- h (9:15) The bridegroom's friends: literally "the sons of the bridal chamber," the wedding guests.
- i (9:17) Wineskins: containers made from the whole skin of a goat. New wine continued to ferment and swell, and old skins, already stretched, would burst.
- j (9:18) A leader: Greek *archōn*, "ruler," probably the leader of a synagogue; Mark 5:22 names him Jairus.
- k (9:20) Tassel: the fringe worn at the corners of the outer garment in obedience to Num 15:38–41 and Deut 22:12.
- l (9:23) Flute players: professional mourners and musicians were customarily hired for funerals.
- m (9:27) Son of David: a title for the Messiah, the promised heir of David's throne (2 Sam 7:12–16; Isa 11:1–10).
- n (9:29) In keeping with your faith: literally "according to your faith."
- o (9:34) This verse is absent from some Western witnesses (Codex Bezae, some Old Latin manuscripts, and the Sinaitic Syriac), and Westcott and Hort placed it in single brackets as doubtful. It is present in all other manuscripts, including Sinaiticus and Vaticanus. Compare 12:24.
- p (9:36) Like sheep with no shepherd: compare Num 27:17; 1 Kgs 22:17; Ezek 34:5.

Chapter 10

1 Jesus called his twelve disciples together and gave them power
over unclean spirits, to cast them out and to cure every sickness and
disease.
2 The twelve apostles[a] were these: first Simon, called Peter, and his
brother Andrew; then James son of Zebedee and his brother John;
3 Philip and Bartholomew; Thomas and Matthew the tax collector;
James son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus;[b] 4 Simon the Cananaean,[c] and
Judas Iscariot,[d] who also betrayed him.
5 These twelve Jesus sent out with these instructions: "Do not go off
onto the roads of the Gentiles, and do not go into any Samaritan
town.[e] 6 Go instead to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. 7 As you
travel, make this announcement: 'The kingdom of heaven is close at
hand.' 8 Heal the sick, raise the dead,[f] make lepers clean, drive out
demons. You received without paying; give without being paid. 9 Take
no gold, no silver, no copper in your belts, 10 nor a bag for the journey,
nor two shirts, nor sandals, nor a staff, for the worker deserves to
be fed.[g] 11 Whatever town or village you enter, find out who in it
is worthy, and stay with him until you leave. 12 As you go into the

house, give it your greeting.[h] 13 If the house is worthy, let your peace
come upon it; but if it is not, let your peace return to you. 14 If anyone
refuses to welcome you or to hear what you say, leave that house or
town and shake the dust from your feet.[i] 15 Amen, I tell you, on the
day of judgment it will be more bearable for the land of Sodom and
Gomorrah than for that town.
16 "See, I send you out as sheep into the midst of wolves. Be wary,
then, as serpents are, and guileless, as doves are. 17 Be on your guard
against people, for they will hand you over to local councils and flog
you in their synagogues; 18 For my sake you will be hauled in front
of governors and kings to give witness to them and to the nations. 19
But when they deliver you up, do not be anxious over how you will
speak or what you will say, for in that hour you will be given what
to say. 20 For it is not you who speak; it is the Spirit of your Father
who speaks in you. 21 One brother will deliver another up to death,
and a father his child; children will rise in revolt against parents and
cause their deaths;[j] 22 and you will be hated by everyone because of my
name. But the one who holds out to the end will be saved. 23 Whenever
they persecute you in one town, escape to the next; amen, I tell you,
before you have completed the circuit of Israel's towns, the Son of
Man will come.
24 "A disciple is not above his teacher, nor a slave above his master. 25
The disciple should be satisfied to be like his teacher, and the slave
like his master. If they named the master of the house Beelzebul,[k] how
much worse names will they give those of his household!
26 "So do not be afraid of them; for there is nothing covered that will
not be uncovered, and nothing hidden that will not be made known.
27 What I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight; and what you
hear whispered in your ear, proclaim from the housetops. 28 Do not
fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Fear rather the
one who can destroy both soul and body in Gehenna. 29 Are not two
sparrows sold for a single small coin?[l] Yet not one of them will fall
to the ground apart from your Father. 30 And as for you, every hair of
your head has been numbered. 31 So do not be afraid; you are of more
value than a great many sparrows.

32 “Whoever, then, acknowledges me before others, I too will acknowledge before my Father in heaven; 33 but whoever disowns me before others, I too will disown before my Father in heaven.
34 “Do not suppose that I came to bring peace upon the earth. I did not come to bring peace, but a sword. 35 I have come to turn a man against his father, a daughter against her mother, and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law; 36 a man will find his enemies among those of his own house.[m] 37 Whoever loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me, and whoever loves son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me. 38 And whoever does not take up his cross and follow after me is not worthy of me. 39 Whoever has found his life will lose it, and whoever has lost his life because of me will find it.
40 “To receive you is to receive me, and to receive me is to receive the one who sent me. 41 Anyone who receives a prophet as a prophet will get a prophet’s reward, and anyone who receives a righteous person as a righteous person will get a righteous person’s reward. 42 And whoever gives even a cup of cold water to one of these little ones because he is a disciple, amen, I tell you, that person will certainly not lose his reward.”

Notes

- a (10:2) Apostles: Greek *apostoloi*, “those sent out,” “envoys.” *Philip* is a Greek name meaning “lover of horses.” *Bartholomew* is Aramaic for “son of Tolmai” (or “of Talmai”).
- b (10:3) Thomas … Thaddaeus: *Thomas* is from Aramaic *teʾoma*, “twin” (see John 11:16). *Alphaeus* is probably from Aramaic *Halfai*. *Thaddaeus* is perhaps from Aramaic *tad*, “breast,” meaning something like “beloved.” Some manuscripts read *Lebbaeus*, or “Lebbaeus who was called Thaddaeus”; the Westcott–Hort text reads *Thaddaeus*. Luke 6:16 and Acts 1:13 have “Judas son of James” in his place.
- c (10:4) Cananaean: from Aramaic *qanʾan*, “zealous one,” not a reference to Canaan. Luke 6:15 calls him “the Zealot.”
- d (10:4) Iscariot: probably Hebrew *ish Qeriyyot*, “man of Kerioth,” a town in southern Judea (Josh 15:25); other explanations have been proposed. *Judas* is the Greek form of *Judah*, “praised” (Gen 29:35).
- e (10:5) Samaritan: the people of Samaria, between Judea and Galilee, who worshiped the God of Israel at Mount Gerizim and accepted only the five books of Moses. Jews and Samaritans were bitterly estranged.
- f (10:8) Raise the dead: some later manuscripts omit these words.

- g (10:10) Deserves to be fed: literally “is worthy of his food.” Compare Luke 10:7; 1 Tim 5:18.
- h (10:12) Give it your greeting: the customary greeting was *shalom*, “peace” (verse 13). Some manuscripts add, “saying, ‘Peace to this house.’ ”
- i (10:14) Shake its dust off your feet: a sign of disowning a place; devout Jews were said to do this when returning from Gentile territory.
- j (10:21) Compare Mic 7:6.
- k (10:25) Beelzebul: a name for the prince of demons (12:24), probably “lord of the dwelling” or “lord of the heights,” perhaps a deliberate twist of *Baal-zebub*, “lord of flies,” the god of Ekron (2 Kgs 1:2). Later manuscripts read *Beelzebub*.
- l (10:29) A single small coin: Greek *assarion*, a Roman copper coin worth one sixteenth of a denarius (a day’s wage), roughly what a laborer earned in forty minutes.
- m (10:36) Mic 7:6.

Chapter 11

1 Once Jesus had completed his charge to the Twelve, he left that place
and went on teaching and proclaiming in the towns of the region.
2 Word reached John in his prison cell about the works of the Messiah,
and he dispatched his disciples 3 with a question: “Is it you who are the
Coming One, or must we wait for a different person?” 4 Jesus replied,
“Go back and tell John what you are hearing and seeing: 5 the blind
regain their sight and the lame walk about, those with leprosy are
made clean and the deaf hear, the dead are raised, and the poor are
hearing good news.[a] 6 Happy is the one who finds in me no cause for
stumbling.”
7 While they were on their way, Jesus spoke to the crowds concerning
John: “When you trekked out into the wilderness, what were you
expecting to look at? A reed shaken by the wind? 8 What, then, did
you go out to see? Someone dressed in soft, fine clothing? Look, those
who wear fine clothing are to be found in royal palaces. 9 What did
you go out to see, then? A prophet? Yes, I tell you, and far more than
a prophet. 10 He is the man of whom Scripture says, ‘Look, I send my
messenger before your face; he will make your road ready ahead of
you.’[b] 11 Amen, I tell you, among all born of women there has never
arisen anyone greater than John the Baptist; yet the one who is least
in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he. 12 From the days of John

the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven has been under violent attack, and violent people are trying to seize it.[c] 13 For all the Prophets and the Law prophesied until John; 14 and if you are willing to accept it, he himself is Elijah, who was to come.[d] 15 Whoever has ears, let him hear.

16 "But to what shall I compare this generation? It is like children sitting in the marketplaces who call out to the others, 17 'We played the flute for you, and you would not dance; we sang a dirge, and you would not beat your breasts.' 18 For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, 'He has a demon.' 19 The Son of Man came eating and drinking, and they say, 'There goes a glutton and a wine-drinker, a crony of tax collectors and sinners!' Yet wisdom is shown to be right by what she does."[e]

20 Then he began to denounce the towns in which most of his mighty works had been done, because they had not changed their ways. 21 "How terrible for you, Chorazin! How terrible for you, Bethsaida![f] If the miracles that happened in you had happened in Tyre and Sidon,[g] they would have repented long ago, in sackcloth and ashes. 22 But I tell you, Tyre and Sidon will find the day of judgment more bearable than you will. 23 And you, Capernaum, will you be raised to heaven? No, you will go down to Hades.[h] If the miracles that happened in you had happened in Sodom, it would still be here today. 24 But I tell you that the land of Sodom will find the day of judgment more bearable than you will."

25 At that time Jesus declared, "Father, Lord of heaven and earth, I thank you for hiding these things from the wise and clever and showing them to little children. 26 Yes, Father, for this is what pleased you. 27 All things have been put into my hands by my Father. None knows the Son fully except the Father; none knows the Father fully except the Son, and anyone to whom the Son is pleased to make him known.

28 "Come to me, all who are weary and weighed down, and I will give you rest. 29 Take my yoke[i] upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.[j] 30 For my yoke is kindly and my load is light."

Notes

- a (11:5) Isa 35:5–6; 26:19; 61:1.
- b (11:10) Mal 3:1; compare Exod 23:20. In Malachi the messenger prepares the way "before me," that is, before Yahweh.
- c (11:12) Has been under violent attack ... seize it: the Greek is difficult. It may also mean "the kingdom of heaven has been forcefully advancing, and forceful people are laying hold of it." Scholarly review recommended.
- d (11:14) Elijah, who was to come: see Mal 4:5–6 (3:23–24 in Hebrew). *Elijah* means "my God is Yahweh."
- e (11:19) By what she does: literally "by her deeds." The Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, reads *ergōn*, "deeds"; most later manuscripts read "by her children," as in Luke 7:35.
- f (11:21) Chorazin ... Bethsaida: towns on or near the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee, close to Capernaum. *Bethsaida* means "house of fishing."
- g (11:21) Tyre and Sidon: Gentile seaports on the Phoenician coast, denounced by the prophets (Isa 23; Ezek 26–28).
- h (11:23) Hades: the Greek name for the realm of the dead, corresponding to Hebrew *Sheol*. Compare Isa 14:13–15.
- i (11:29) Yoke: the wooden frame laid on the necks of draft animals; in Jewish usage, a figure for submission to the Law or to the teaching of a rabbi.
- j (11:29) Jer 6:16.

Chapter 12

1 About that time, on a Sabbath day, Jesus was walking through fields
of grain.[a] His disciples were hungry, and they started to pluck the
ears and eat them. 2 The Pharisees saw it and told him, "See there!
Your disciples are doing what the Sabbath does not allow." 3 He said
to them, "Have you never read what David did when he and his
companions were hungry, 4 how he went into the house of God and
they ate the consecrated bread,[b] which neither he nor his companions
were permitted to eat, but only the priests?[c] 5 Or have you never
read in the Law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple break
the Sabbath and yet are blameless?[d] 6 I tell you, here is something
greater than the temple. 7 If you had grasped what this means, 'It is
mercy I desire, and not sacrifice,'[e] you would not have condemned the
innocent. 8 For the Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath."
9 Moving on from there, he went into their synagogue. 10 A man was
there with a shriveled hand. Looking for a charge to bring against
Jesus, they asked him, "Is healing on the Sabbath permitted?" 11 He

said to them, “Suppose one of you has a single sheep and it tumbles into a pit on the Sabbath: will he not grab it and pull it out? 12 A man is worth so much more than a sheep! It is lawful, then, to do good on Sabbath days.” 13 Then he said to the man, “Stretch out your hand.” He stretched it out, and it was healthy again, like the other one. 14 But the Pharisees went out and plotted against him, how they might do away with him.

15 Jesus knew of this and withdrew from there. Many[f] followed him, and he healed them all, 16 and he sternly ordered them not to make him known. 17 This was to fulfill what was spoken through Isaiah the prophet: 18 “Here is my servant, whom I have chosen, my beloved, in whom my soul delights. I will put my Spirit upon him, and he will announce justice to the nations. 19 He will not quarrel or shout, nor will anyone hear his voice in the streets. 20 He will not snap a bent reed, nor quench a flickering wick, till he has led justice on to victory. 21 And in his name the nations will put their hope.”[g]

22 Then they brought him a man under a demon’s power, blind and mute, and Jesus healed him, so that he spoke and saw. 23 The crowds, all of them amazed, kept saying, “Might this man be the Son of David?” 24 Hearing this, the Pharisees said, “It is only through Beelzebul, prince of the demons, that this fellow casts the demons out.” 25 Knowing their thoughts, Jesus said to them, “Any kingdom split against itself ends in ruin, and any town or family split against itself cannot last. 26 If Satan drives out Satan, he is divided against himself; how then will his kingdom stand? 27 And if it is through Beelzebul that I cast out demons, through whom do your own people[h] cast them out? They, then, will be your judges. 28 But if I cast the demons out through God’s Spirit, the kingdom of God has arrived among you. 29 Or how can someone enter a strong man’s house and steal his belongings without first tying up the strong man? Then he can rob the house. 30 Anyone not on my side opposes me, and anyone not gathering with me is scattering.

31 “So I say to you: every sin and blasphemy people commit will be forgiven, but blasphemy against the Spirit will find no forgiveness.[i] 32 Someone who says something against the Son of Man will be

forgiven, but someone who speaks against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven, not in this age, and not in the one to come.
33 "Make the tree good and its fruit will be good, or make the tree bad
and its fruit will be bad. A tree is recognized by its fruit. 34 You brood
of vipers, how can you say anything good when you are evil? For the
mouth speaks out of what overflows from the heart. 35 A good person,
from the good stored up within, brings out good; an evil person, from
the evil stored up within, brings out evil. 36 I tell you, every thoughtless
word that people utter they will answer for on judgment day; 37 for
by your words you will be acquitted, and by your words you will be
condemned."
38 Then some of the scribes and Pharisees responded to him, "Teacher,
we want to see a sign from you." 39 He answered, "A wicked and
unfaithful[j] generation looks for a sign, but none will be given it except
the sign of the prophet Jonah.[k] 40 Just as Jonah spent three days and
three nights inside the belly of the great fish,[l] so the Son of Man will
spend three days and three nights in the depths of the earth. 41 On
judgment day the people of Nineveh will rise with this generation
and pronounce it guilty, for they turned from their ways when Jonah
preached; and here is something greater than Jonah. 42 The queen
of the South[m] will rise up at the judgment with this generation and
condemn it, because she came from the ends of the earth to listen
to Solomon's wisdom; and look, something greater than Solomon is
here.
43 "When an unclean spirit has gone out of a person, it roams through
waterless places seeking rest, and finds none. 44 Then it says, 'I will go
back to my house that I left.' And when it comes, it finds the house
empty, swept clean, and put in order. 45 Then off it goes and fetches
seven more spirits, worse than itself, and they move in and make their
home there; and that person ends up in a worse state than at the start.
So it will be with this wicked generation too."
46 He was still talking with the crowds when his mother and brothers[n]
came and stood outside, seeking to speak to him. 47 [Someone said
to him, "Your mother and brothers are out there, and they want a
word with you."][o] 48 But he replied to the one who told him, "Who

is my mother, and who are my brothers?" [49] Then he pointed to his disciples and said, "See, these are my mother and my brothers! [50] For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother."

Notes

- a (12:1) Sabbath: from Hebrew *shabbat*, "ceasing," "rest," the seventh day of the week (Friday sunset to Saturday sunset), on which work was forbidden (Exod 20:8–11). Picking grain by hand from a neighbor's field was allowed (Deut 23:25), but the Pharisees counted it as reaping, a kind of work.
- b (12:4) Consecrated bread: literally "the bread of the presentation," the twelve loaves set out each week before God in the sanctuary (Lev 24:5–9).
- c (12:4) 1 Sam 21:1–6.
- d (12:5) Num 28:9–10.
- e (12:7) Hos 6:6; see 9:13.
- f (12:15) Many: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, reads "many"; later manuscripts read "great crowds."
- g (12:21) Isa 42:1–4, quoted freely, partly following the Hebrew and partly the Greek Old Testament (verse 21).
- h (12:27) Your own people: literally "your sons," that is, Jewish exorcists associated with the Pharisees.
- i (12:31) Blasphemy against the Spirit: attributing to Satan the work that God's Spirit is plainly doing (12:24, 28).
- j (12:39) Unfaithful: the Greek says "adulterous," meaning unfaithful to God, as in the prophets' picture of Israel as an unfaithful wife (Hos 2; Ezek 16).
- k (12:39) Jonah: "dove." See the book of Jonah, especially 1:17 and 3:5.
- l (12:40) Sea monster: Greek *kētos*, "huge fish" or "sea creature" (Jonah 1:17 in the Greek Old Testament).
- m (12:42) The queen of the South: the queen of Sheba, probably in southwest Arabia (1 Kgs 10:1–10).
- n (12:46) His brothers: named in 13:55. Catholic and Orthodox tradition understands them as cousins or as children of Joseph by an earlier marriage.
- o (12:47) The Westcott–Hort text, with the first hand of Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and a few other witnesses, omits this verse, placing it in the margin; most manuscripts include it, and it is needed to make sense of verse 48. It is printed here in brackets.

Chapter 13

[1] That same day Jesus went out of the house and sat down beside the lake. [2] So many people crowded around him that he stepped into a boat and sat down in it, and all the people stood along the beach. [3] He spoke to them at length in parables.[a] "Listen," he said. "A sower went

out to scatter seed. 4 As he scattered it, some fell beside the path, and
birds swooped down and devoured it. 5 Other seed fell on rocky places
where it did not have much soil, and it sprang up at once because the
soil was shallow; 6 When the sun rose, the young plants were scorched
and, having no root, dried up. 7 Other seed fell among thornbushes,
and the thorns grew up and choked it. 8 Still other seed fell on good
soil and yielded a crop, some a hundred times as much, some sixty,
some thirty. 9 Whoever has ears, let him hear."
10 The disciples approached him and said, "Why are you talking to
them in parables?" 11 He replied, "You have been granted knowledge
of the secrets[b] of the kingdom of heaven; they have not. 12 Whoever
has something will be given more and will have plenty; whoever has
nothing will lose even what they have. 13 This is why I speak to them
in parables: because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not
hear or understand. 14 In them the prophecy of Isaiah is being fulfilled,
which says, 'You will listen and listen, yet never understand; you
will look and look, yet never perceive. 15 For this people's heart has
grown dull; with their ears they barely hear, and they have shut their
eyes, so that they may not see with their eyes, hear with their ears,
understand with their heart, and turn back, and I would heal them.'[c]
16 But blessed are your eyes, because they see, and your ears, because
they hear. 17 Amen, I tell you, many prophets and righteous people
yearned to see the things you see, but never saw them, and to hear
the things you hear, but never heard them.
18 "Listen, then, to what the parable of the sower means. 19 When
anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it,
the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart;
this is the seed sown along the path. 20 The seed sown on rocky places
is the one who hears the word and at once receives it with joy; 21 Yet
it has no root in them and lasts only a short time. When trouble or
persecution arises on account of the word, they quickly fall away. 22
The seed that fell among thorns stands for the one who hears the
word, but worldly worries and the deceit of riches smother the word,
and it bears no fruit. 23 But the seed sown on the good soil is the one

who hears the word and understands it; he indeed bears fruit and yields, one a hundredfold, another sixty, another thirty."
24 He told them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven can be compared to a man who planted good seed in his field. 25 But while everyone was asleep, his enemy came and sowed darnel[d] among the wheat and went away. 26 When the wheat sprouted and formed heads of grain, then the darnel appeared too. 27 The servants of the landowner approached him and said, 'Master, was it not good seed you planted in your field? So where did the weeds come from?' 28 He told them, 'An enemy has done this.' The slaves asked him, 'Do you want us, then, to go and pull it up?' 29 But he said, 'No; in pulling up the darnel you might uproot the wheat along with it. 30 Let them both grow together until the harvest. When the time comes, I will tell the harvesters: First collect the weeds and bundle them up to burn; then bring the wheat into my barn.' "
31 He put before them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed, which a man took and sowed in his field. 32 Of all seeds it is the tiniest, yet when full grown it is bigger than any garden plant; it becomes a tree, and the birds of the sky come and make their nests among its branches."[e]
33 He told them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like yeast that a woman took and worked into about fifty pounds of flour[f] until the whole batch was leavened."
34 Jesus told the crowds all these things in parables; indeed, he told them nothing without a parable. 35 This fulfilled what was spoken through the prophet:[g] "I will open my mouth in parables; I will pour out things hidden since the foundation of the world."[h]
36 Then he left the crowds and went into the house. His disciples came to him and said, "Explain to us the parable of the darnel in the field."
37 He answered, "The one who sows the good seed is the Son of Man. 38 The field is the world; the good seed stands for the children of the kingdom; the darnel stands for the children of the evil one; 39 the enemy who sowed it is the devil; the harvest is the end of the age; and the reapers are angels. 40 Just as the darnel is gathered and burned up in the fire, so will it be at the end of the age. 41 The Son of Man will

send his angels, and they will remove from his kingdom everyone who leads others into sin and everyone who does wrong, 42 and they will throw them into the blazing furnace; there people will weep and grind their teeth. 43 Then the righteous will shine like the sun in their Father's kingdom.[i] Whoever has ears, let him hear.

44 "The kingdom of heaven is like a treasure hidden in a field. A man found it and hid it again, and in his joy he went and sold all that he owned and bought that field.

45 "Or again, the kingdom of heaven is like a trader on the lookout for beautiful pearls. 46 When he found one pearl of great price, he went away and sold everything he had and bought it.

47 "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a dragnet that was let down into the lake and caught fish of every kind. 48 When it was full, they hauled it onto the shore, sat down, and collected the good fish into containers, but threw away the worthless ones. 49 It will be that way at the end of the age: the angels will come, separate the evil from the righteous, 50 and throw them into the blazing furnace; there people will weep and grind their teeth.

51 "Have you understood all this?" They said to him, "Yes." 52 He said to them, "That is why every scribe trained for the kingdom of heaven is like a householder, who brings both new treasures and old out of his storeroom."

53 When Jesus had finished these parables, he left that place. 54 Coming to his hometown,[j] he taught the people in their synagogue, and they were astounded and said, "Where did this man get this wisdom and these mighty powers? 55 This is the carpenter's son,[k] is he not? His mother is Mary, isn't she, and his brothers are James, Joseph,[l] Simon and Judas? 56 And are not all his sisters here with us? Where then did he get all this?" 57 And they took offense at him. But Jesus said to them, "A prophet is not without honor except in his hometown and in his own house." 58 And he did not do many mighty works there because of their unbelief.

Notes

- a (13:3) Parables: Greek *parabolē*, "comparison," corresponding to Hebrew *mashal*, a saying, proverb, riddle or illustrative story.

- b (13:11) Secrets: Greek *mystēria*, things hidden in God's purpose and now revealed.
- c (13:15) Isa 6:9–10, quoted in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- d (13:25) Darnel: Greek *zizania*, a weed (*Lolium temulentum*) that closely resembles wheat until it forms its head. Its seeds are bitter and mildly poisonous. Traditionally "tares."
- e (13:32) The birds … nest in its branches: compare Ps 104:12; Ezek 17:23; 31:6; Dan 4:12, 21.
- f (13:33) About fifty pounds of flour: literally "three *sata*" of flour. A *saton* (Hebrew *seah*) was about 13 quarts (12–13 liters), so the total was about 10 gallons (39 liters), enough bread for well over a hundred people. Compare Gen 18:6.
- g (13:35) The prophet: a few manuscripts, including the first hand of Sinaiticus, read "Isaiah the prophet"; the quotation is from Asaph (Ps 78), whom 2 Chr 29:30 calls a seer.
- h (13:35) Ps 78:2.
- i (13:43) Compare Dan 12:3.
- j (13:54) His hometown: Nazareth (2:23).
- k (13:55) Carpenter: Greek *tektōn*, a craftsman who worked in wood or stone, a builder.
- l (13:55) Joseph: later manuscripts read *Joses* (as in Mark 6:3) or *John*. *James* is *Jacob* (see 4:21 note); *Judas* is *Judah*.

Chapter 14

1 At that time Herod the tetrarch[a] heard the reports about Jesus, 2 and told his attendants, "This is John the Baptist. He has risen from the dead, and that is why miraculous powers are working in him."

3 For Herod had arrested John, bound him, and put him in prison on account of Herodias, the wife of his brother Philip,[b] 4 because John had been telling him, "It is against the law for you to have her."[c] 5 Herod wanted to put him to death, but he was afraid of the people, because they regarded John as a prophet. 6 But on Herod's birthday, the daughter of Herodias[d] danced before the guests, and Herod was so delighted 7 that he swore an oath to give her whatever she asked. 8 Prompted by her mother, she said, "Give me here on a platter the head of John the Baptist." 9 The king was grieved, but because of his oaths and his guests he ordered it to be given her. 10 He sent orders, and John was beheaded in the prison. 11 His head was brought on a platter and given to the girl, and she brought it to her mother. 12 John's disciples came, took his body and buried it, and then went and informed Jesus.

13 When Jesus heard it, he withdrew from there by boat to a deserted
place to be by himself. But the crowds learned of it and followed
him on foot from the towns. 14 When he came ashore, he saw a great
crowd, and he was moved with compassion for them and healed their
sick. 15 With evening approaching, the disciples came to him. "This is
a lonely spot," they said, "and the day is far gone. Let the people go,
so that they can make their way to the villages and get provisions
for themselves." 16 But Jesus said, "There is no need for them to leave.
You yourselves give them food." 17 They said to him, "All we have here
are five loaves and two fish." 18 He said, "Bring them here to me." 19
Then he directed the crowds to sit down on the grass. He took the five
loaves and the two fish, and looking up to heaven he said a blessing;
he broke the loaves and gave them to the disciples, and the disciples
gave them to the crowds. 20 Everyone ate and was satisfied, and they
gathered up what was left over of the broken pieces, twelve baskets
full. 21 Those who ate were about five thousand men, besides women
and children.
22 Immediately he made the disciples get into the boat and go on ahead
of him to the other side, while he sent the crowds away. 23 When he
had dismissed them, he climbed the mountain alone to pray. Evening
fell, and he was there by himself, 24 but the boat was by this time a long
way from land,[e] being battered by the waves, for the wind was against
it. 25 Between three and six in the morning[f] he came toward them,
walking on the lake. 26 When the disciples saw him walking across
the lake, they were terrified. "It is a ghost!" they said, and screamed
in fear. 27 But at once Jesus spoke to them: "Take heart; it is I.[g] Do not
be afraid." 28 Peter answered him, "Lord, if it is you, command me to
come to you on the water." 29 "Come," said Jesus. Peter climbed out of
the boat and walked on the water, making his way toward Jesus. 30
But when he saw the wind,[h] he became frightened, and beginning to
sink, he cried out, "Lord, save me!" 31 Jesus immediately reached out
his hand and caught hold of him, saying to him, "You of little faith,
why did you doubt?" 32 And when they had climbed into the boat, the
wind died down. 33 Those in the boat bowed down before him and
said, "Truly you are the Son of God."

34 When they had crossed over, they came to land at Gennesaret.[i] 35
When the men of that place recognized him, they sent word into all
that surrounding region and brought to him all who were sick, 36 and
they begged him that they might merely touch the tassel of his cloak;
and all who touched it were made completely well.

Notes

- a (14:1) Herod the tetrarch: Herod Antipas, son of Herod the Great, ruler of Galilee and Perea from 4 BC to AD 39. *Tetrarch* ("ruler of a fourth") was a title for a minor ruler under Rome; Matthew also calls him "king" (verse 9).
- b (14:3) Herodias … Philip: Herodias was a granddaughter of Herod the Great. She had been married to her uncle Herod (called Philip here and in Mark 6:17), and left him to marry his half-brother Antipas. Some manuscripts omit "Philip." The historian Josephus gives a fuller account (*Antiquities* 18.5).
- c (14:4) Against the law: Lev 18:16; 20:21.
- d (14:6) The daughter of Herodias: named Salome by Josephus.
- e (14:24) A long way from land: literally "many stadia from the land." A stadion was about 607 feet (185 m). The Westcott–Hort text follows Vaticanus here; other manuscripts read "in the middle of the lake." Compare John 6:19, "about 25 or 30 stadia," about 3 or 3½ miles (5 or 6 km).
- f (14:25) Between three and six in the morning: literally "in the fourth watch of the night." The Romans divided the night into four watches: about 6–9 p.m., 9 p.m.–midnight, midnight–3 a.m., and 3–6 a.m.
- g (14:27) It is I: Greek *egō eimi*, literally "I am," which may echo God's self-identification in Exod 3:14 and Isa 43:10.
- h (14:30) Saw the wind: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks "strong," which most manuscripts add.
- i (14:34) Gennesaret: a fertile plain on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee, between Capernaum and Magdala.

Chapter 15

1 Then some Pharisees and scribes came to Jesus from Jerusalem with
a question: 2 "What makes your disciples break the tradition handed
down by the elders? They do not wash their hands before they eat
bread."[a] 3 He answered them, "And what makes you break God's
commandment for the sake of your tradition? 4 God said, 'Honor your
father and mother,'[b] and, 'Whoever reviles father or mother must cer-
tainly be put to death.'[c] 5 Yet you teach that a person can say to father
or mother, 'Anything of mine that might have helped you is a gift
devoted to God,'[d] 6 he need not honor his father at all. So for the sake

of your tradition you have cancelled the word[e] of God. 7 Hypocrites!
Isaiah described you well when he prophesied: 8 'This people honors
me with their lips, while their heart stays far away from me; 9 their
worship of me is empty, for what they teach as doctrine are human
rules.' "[f]
10 Then he called the crowd over and said to them, "Listen, and
understand this: 11 a person is not made unclean by what goes into the
mouth; what comes out of the mouth, that is what makes a person
unclean." 12 Then the disciples came and said to him, "Are you aware
that the Pharisees were offended to hear you say this?" 13 He replied,
"Any plant that my heavenly Father has not planted will be uprooted.
14 Leave them be. They are blind guides; and when one blind man
guides another, the two of them will tumble into a ditch."[g] 15 Peter
spoke up: "Explain this saying to us." 16 "Are you also still slow to grasp
it?" Jesus said. 17 "Do you not see that whatever enters the mouth
passes into the stomach and goes out into the latrine? 18 What comes
out of the mouth, though, issues from the heart, and that is what
defiles a person. 19 For from the heart come evil schemes, murders,
adulteries, sexual immoralities, thefts, false witness, slanders. 20 These
are what make a person unclean; but eating with hands unwashed
does not make anyone unclean."
21 Jesus left that area and went to the district of Tyre and Sidon. 22 And
a Canaanite[h] woman from that territory came out and kept crying,
"Have mercy on me, Lord, Son of David! My daughter is tormented
by a demon, and it is terrible." 23 But he gave her no word of answer.
His disciples came to him and urged him, "Send her off; she keeps
shouting after us." 24 He answered, "I was sent to no one but the lost
sheep of the house of Israel." 25 But she came and knelt before him.
"Lord," she said, "help me!" 26 He answered, "It is not right to take
bread meant for the children and toss it to the little dogs." 27 "True,
Lord," she said, "yet even the little dogs eat the scraps falling from
their masters' table." 28 Then Jesus answered her, "Woman, great is
your faith! Let it be done for you just as you wish." And her daughter
was healed from that hour.

29 Jesus moved on from there and went along the shore of the Sea
of Galilee. He climbed a hillside and sat there. 30 Great crowds came
to him, bringing with them people who were lame, crippled, blind,
mute, and many others besides, and laid them at his feet, and he
healed them. 31 The crowd marveled as they saw the mute talking, the
maimed restored,[i] the lame walking and the blind seeing, and they
praised the God of Israel.
32 Jesus called his disciples to him and said, "My heart goes out to
these people, because for three days now they have stayed with me
and they have nothing left to eat. I am not willing to send them away
hungry; they might faint on the road." 33 His disciples asked him,
"Where in this remote place could we find enough bread to feed such
a large crowd?" 34 Jesus asked them, "How many loaves have you got?"
They said, "Seven, and a few small fish." 35 He instructed the crowd to
sit down on the ground, 36 and he took the seven loaves and the fish,
gave thanks, broke them, and kept handing them to the disciples, and
the disciples handed them to the crowds. 37 They all ate their fill, and
they collected the broken pieces that remained, seven large baskets
full.[j] 38 There were four thousand men who ate, in addition to women
and children. 39 After dismissing the crowds, he got into the boat and
came to the district of Magadan.[k]

Notes

- a (15:2) Wash their hands: ritual washing, not hygiene. The "tradition of the elders" was the body of oral rulings by which the Pharisees applied the Law (compare Mark 7:3–4).
- b (15:4) Exod 20:12; Deut 5:16.
- c (15:4) Exod 21:17; Lev 20:9.
- d (15:5) A gift devoted to God: something dedicated to God (Mark 7:11 gives the Aramaic term, *Corban*) and therefore, by the rule being criticized, unavailable to support one's parents.
- e (15:6) Word: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus (corrected) and Vaticanus, reads "word"; some manuscripts read "commandment" and others "law."
- f (15:9) Isa 29:13, quoted in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- g (15:14) Many later manuscripts read "blind guides of the blind"; the Westcott–Hort text reads simply "blind guides."
- h (15:22) Canaanite: an old biblical name for the non-Israelite peoples of the region; Mark 7:26 calls her "a Greek, Syrophoenician by birth."

- i (15:31) The crippled made whole: the first hand of Sinaiticus and a few other witnesses omit this phrase.
- j (15:37) Large baskets: Greek *spyris*, a larger basket than the *kophinos* of 14:20.
- k (15:39) Magadan: location uncertain. Later manuscripts read *Magdala*; compare Mark 8:10, "Dalmanutha."

Chapter 16

1 Pharisees and Sadducees approached, testing him, and demanded
that he show them some sign out of heaven. 2 He answered them,
[["When evening comes, you say, 'Fair weather, for the sky is red';
3 and in the morning, 'Today there will be a storm, because the sky
is red and threatening.' You can interpret the appearance of the sky,
but you cannot interpret the signs of the times.]][a] 4 A wicked and
adulterous generation clamors for a sign, but it will be given no sign
except the sign of Jonah." Then he left them and went away.
5 When the disciples reached the far shore, they found that they had
forgotten to take bread. 6 Jesus said to them, "Watch out, and be
on guard against the yeast[b] of the Pharisees and Sadducees." 7 They
discussed this among themselves and said, "He says this because we
brought no bread." 8 Jesus knew what they were saying and asked,
"Why all this talk among yourselves about having no bread, you
people of little faith? 9 Have you not understood yet? Have you
forgotten the five loaves that fed five thousand, and the number of
baskets you filled with leftovers? 10 Or the seven loaves for the four
thousand, and how many large baskets you gathered? 11 How can you
not understand that I was not speaking about bread? Watch out for
the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees!" 12 Then it dawned on them
that he had not told them to beware of the yeast in bread, but of what
the Pharisees and Sadducees taught.
13 When Jesus came into the district of Caesarea Philippi,[c] he put a
question to his disciples: "Who do people say that the Son of Man is?"
14 They said, "Some say John the Baptist; others, Elijah; and still others,
Jeremiah[d] or one of the prophets." 15 He said to them, "And you—who
do you say I am?" 16 Simon Peter spoke up: "You are the Messiah, Son
of the living God." 17 Jesus answered him, "Blessed are you, Simon son
of Jonah,[e] for no human being[f] revealed this to you, but my Father in

heaven. 18 And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock[g] I will build
my church,[h] and the gates of Hades[i] will not overpower it. 19 The keys
of the kingdom of heaven I will place in your hands. Whatever you
bind on earth will already be bound in heaven, and whatever you
release on earth will already be released in heaven."[j] 20 Then he gave
the disciples strict orders not to tell anyone that he was the Messiah.
21 From then on Jesus[k] started to explain to his disciples that he must
go to Jerusalem and endure great suffering from the elders, chief
priests and scribes, be killed, and rise again on the third day. 22 Peter
took him aside and began to rebuke him: "God have mercy on you,[l]
Lord! This must never happen to you!" 23 But he turned and said to
Peter, "Get behind me, Satan! You are a stumbling block to me, for
your thinking is not God's way of thinking but man's."
24 Then Jesus said to his disciples, "If anyone wants to come after me,
let him say no to himself, take up his cross, and follow me. 25 Anyone
set on saving his life[m] will lose it, and anyone who loses his life for my
sake will find it. 26 What will it profit anyone to win the entire world
and lose their life? Or what can a person give to get life back? 27 The
Son of Man will come in the glory of his Father with his angels, and
then he will repay each person according to their actions.[n] 28 Amen, I
tell you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until
they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom."

Notes

- a (16:3) Verses 2b–3 (from "When evening comes" to "the signs of the times") are absent from Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and other early witnesses, and Jerome knew manuscripts without them. Westcott and Hort enclosed them in double brackets as not part of Matthew's original text, though very old. They are printed here in double brackets. The Greek *pyrrazei* means "is fiery red."
- b (16:6) Yeast: here a figure for a corrupting influence that spreads unseen (verse 12; compare 1 Cor 5:6–8).
- c (16:13) Caesarea Philippi: a town at the foot of Mount Hermon near the source of the Jordan, rebuilt by Herod's son Philip and named in honor of Caesar Augustus (and to distinguish it from Caesarea on the coast).
- d (16:14) Jeremiah: "Yahweh exalts" or "Yahweh throws (down)."
- e (16:17) Son of Jonah: Aramaic *Bar-Jona*. John 1:42 and 21:15 call his father John.
- f (16:17) No human being: literally "flesh and blood."

- g (16:18) Peter ... rock: a wordplay. *Petros* (Peter) and *petra* (rock) are related Greek words, both rendering the Aramaic name *Kepha* (Cephas), "rock" (John 1:42).
- h (16:18) Church: Greek *ekklēsia*, "assembly," used in the Greek Old Testament for the assembly of Israel.
- i (16:18) The gates of Hades: the power of death.
- j (16:19) Will have been bound ... will have been loosed: or "will be bound ... will be loosed." Binding and loosing were rabbinic terms for forbidding and permitting, and also for imposing or lifting a penalty. Compare 18:18.
- k (16:21) Jesus: Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus read "Jesus Christ" here, as does the Westcott–Hort text; most manuscripts read "Jesus."
- l (16:22) God have mercy on you: an idiom meaning "God forbid!"
- m (16:25) Life: Greek *psychē*, which can mean "life" or "soul" (also in verse 26).
- n (16:27) Ps 62:12; Prov 24:12.

Chapter 17

1 After six days Jesus brought Peter, James, and his brother John up a
high mountain by themselves. 2 And he was transformed before them;
his face shone like the sun, and his clothes became as white as the
light. 3 And suddenly Moses and Elijah[a] appeared to them, talking
with him. 4 Peter responded to Jesus, "Lord, it is good that we are here.
If you wish, I will put up three shelters[b] here: one for you, one for
Moses, and one for Elijah." 5 He was still speaking when a bright cloud
spread its shadow over them, and out of the cloud a voice said, "This
is my Son, my beloved, in whom I delight. Listen to him!"[c] 6 At the
sound of it the disciples fell face down on the ground, overcome with
fear. 7 But Jesus came and touched them. "Get up," he said, "and do
not be afraid." 8 When they raised their eyes, they saw no one except
Jesus himself, alone.
9 As they were coming down from the mountain, Jesus ordered them,
"Tell no one what you have seen until the Son of Man has risen from
the dead." 10 The disciples asked him, "Why then do the scribes say
that Elijah must come first?" 11 He replied, "Elijah is indeed coming,
and he will set everything right again.[d] 12 But I tell you that Elijah
has already come, and they did not recognize him, but did to him
whatever they pleased. In the same way the Son of Man is about to

suffer at their hands." 13 Then it became clear to the disciples that he had been talking to them about John the Baptist.
14 When they reached the crowd, a man came up to Jesus and fell on his knees before him. 15 and said, "Lord, take pity on my son. He has seizures[e] and is in terrible pain; he often falls into the fire and often into the water. 16 I brought him to your disciples, but they had no power to cure him." 17 Jesus replied, "O faithless and twisted generation![f] How long shall I remain with you? How long shall I bear with you? Bring the boy to me here." 18 Jesus spoke sternly to the demon, and it left the boy; from that hour he was well.
19 Afterward the disciples came to Jesus privately and asked, "Why were we not able to drive it out?" 20 "Because you have so little faith," he told them. "Amen, I tell you, if you have faith no bigger than a grain of mustard seed, you will tell this mountain, 'Go over there,' and over there it will go. Nothing will be impossible for you." 21 g
22 While they were gathering[h] in Galilee, Jesus said to them, "The Son of Man is about to be handed over into human hands, 23 They will put him to death, and on the third day he will be raised up." And the disciples were deeply saddened.
24 After they arrived in Capernaum, the men who collected the temple tax[i] came to Peter. "Your teacher pays the temple tax, doesn't he?" they asked. 25 "Yes, he does," Peter said. When he came into the house, Jesus spoke first: "What do you think, Simon? From whom do the kings of the earth collect tolls or tribute? From their own sons, or from others?" 26 When Peter said, "From others," Jesus told him, "Then the sons are exempt. 27 However, so that we do not offend them, go to the lake and throw in a fishhook. Take the first fish that bites, open its mouth, and you will find a silver coin[j] to cover the tax for both of us. Take it and pay them for you and me."

Notes

- a (17:3) Moses and Elijah: representing the Law and the Prophets. Both had met God on a mountain (Exod 24; 33–34; 1 Kgs 19). *Moses* is explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out."
- b (17:4) Shelters: Greek *skēnē*, "tent," "booth," perhaps recalling the booths of the Feast of Tabernacles (Lev 23:42) or the tabernacle in the wilderness.
- c (17:5) Compare Ps 2:7; Isa 42:1; Deut 18:15; and 3:17.

- d (17:11) Mal 4:5–6 (3:23–24 in Hebrew).
- e (17:15) Has seizures: literally “is moonstruck” (Greek *selēniazetai*), a term for epilepsy-like attacks, blamed on the moon.
- f (17:17) Faithless and perverse generation: compare Deut 32:5, 20.
- g (17:21) The Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts (including Sinaiticus, first hand, and Vaticanus) do not include verse 21, and the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Many later manuscripts add, from Mark 9:29, “But this kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.”
- h (17:22) Gathering: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, reads *systrephomenōn*, “gathering together”; most manuscripts read “staying.”
- i (17:24) The temple tax: literally “the two drachmas,” the half-shekel paid yearly by every Jewish man for the upkeep of the temple (Exod 30:13–16; Neh 10:32), equal to about two days’ wages.
- j (17:27) A silver coin: Greek *statēr*, a coin worth four drachmas, enough to pay the temple tax for two people.

Chapter 18

1 At that time the disciples came to Jesus with the question, “Who,
then, ranks highest in the kingdom of heaven?” 2 He called a little
child over, stood the child among them, 3 and said, “Amen, I tell you,
if you do not turn around and become as little children are, there is
no way you will enter the kingdom of heaven. 4 So whoever takes the
lowly place of this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven. 5
And whoever welcomes one such child in my name welcomes me.
6 “But whoever leads astray one of these little ones who trust in me
would be better off with a large millstone[a] tied around their neck and
drowned in the deep sea. 7 Alas for the world because of its snares!
Snares there must be; but alas for the one through whom the snare
comes! 8 If your hand or your foot leads you into sin, cut it off and
throw it from you. Better for you to enter life maimed or lame than
to keep both hands or both feet and be thrown into the everlasting
fire. 9 And if your eye causes you to sin, pull it out and throw it away.
It is better for you to enter life with one eye than to be thrown into
the fire of Gehenna with two.
10 “Take care that you do not look down on one of these little ones;
for I tell you that in heaven their angels are always looking upon the
face of my Father in heaven.[b] 11 [c] 12 What is your opinion? If a man has
a hundred sheep and one of them wanders off, will he not leave the

ninety-nine on the hillsides and go in search of the stray? 13 And if he
happens to find it, amen, I tell you, he rejoices over it more than over
the ninety-nine that never wandered. 14 In the same way, it is not the
will of your[d] Father in heaven that a single one of these little ones
should be lost.
15 "If your brother sins[e] against you, go to him privately and show him
where he went wrong, just the two of you. If he pays attention to
you, you have won your brother back. 16 But if he will not listen, take
one or two others along with you, so that 'on the evidence of two or
three witnesses every matter may be settled.'[f] 17 If he refuses to listen
to them, tell it to the church;[g] and if he refuses to listen even to the
church, treat him as you would a Gentile or a tax collector. 18 Amen, I
tell you, whatever you prohibit[h] on earth will already be prohibited in
heaven, and whatever you allow on earth will already be allowed in
heaven. 19 Once more, amen, I tell you: when two of you here on earth
are of one mind about any request they make, my Father in heaven
will do it for them. 20 For where two or three have come together in
my name, there I am in their midst."
21 Then Peter came up and asked him, "Lord, how often shall my
brother sin against me and I forgive him? Up to seven times?" 22 "Not
up to seven times, I say to you," Jesus replied, "but up to seventy-
seven times.[i]
23 "For this reason the kingdom of heaven is like a king who wanted
to settle accounts with his servants. 24 When he began the reckoning,
a man was brought to him who owed ten thousand bags of silver.[j] 25
Since he had no means of paying, his master ordered that he be sold,
together with his wife and children and everything he owned, and
the debt repaid. 26 So the slave fell down and lay prostrate before him,
pleading, 'Be patient with me, and I will pay you everything.' 27 Moved
with pity, the master of that slave released him and canceled the debt.
28 But that same slave went out and came upon one of his fellow slaves
who owed him a hundred days' wages.[k] He seized him by the throat
and began choking him, saying, 'Pay up what you owe!' 29 His fellow
slave fell down and begged him, 'Be patient with me, and I will pay
you.' 30 But he would not hear of it; instead he went off and had him

thrown into prison until he should pay the debt. 31 When his fellow slaves saw what had happened, they were deeply distressed, and they went and reported the whole affair to their master. 32 Then the master summoned him and said to him, ‘You wicked slave! I canceled that entire debt of yours because you begged me. 33 Ought you not to have shown mercy to your fellow slave, as I showed mercy to you?’ 34 And in anger his master handed him over to the jailers[l] until he should repay everything owed. 35 That is how my heavenly Father will deal with each of you, unless you forgive your brother from your heart.”

Notes

- a (18:6) Heavy millstone: literally “a donkey’s millstone,” the large upper stone of a mill turned by a donkey.
- b (18:10) Compare Ps 34:7; 91:11; Heb 1:14.
- c (18:11) The Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts (including Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and the Greek of the early versions) do not include verse 11; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Many later manuscripts add, from Luke 19:10, “For the Son of Man came to save the lost.”
- d (18:14) Your: some manuscripts, including Vaticanus, read “my.”
- e (18:15) If your brother sins: most manuscripts add “against you”; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, omits it (WH prints it in the margin).
- f (18:16) Deut 19:15.
- g (18:17) Church: Greek *ekklēsia*, “assembly” (see 16:18 note), here the local community of disciples.
- h (18:18) Forbid … permit: literally “bind … loose”; see 16:19 note.
- i (18:22) Seventy-seven times: or “seventy times seven.” The Greek is ambiguous, but it matches Gen 4:24 in the Greek Old Testament, where Lamech boasts of revenge “seventy-seven times.”
- j (18:24) Ten thousand bags of silver: literally “ten thousand talents.” A talent was a weight of silver of about 75 pounds (34 kg), worth about 6,000 denarii, that is, about 6,000 days’ wages for a laborer. The sum is deliberately beyond all reckoning: some 60 million days’ wages. Ten thousand (*myrioi*) was the largest number in Greek counting.
- k (18:28) A hundred days’ wages: the Greek says “a hundred denarii,” and a denarius was what a laborer typically earned in a day (20:2). The debt was about one six-hundred-thousandth of the first.
- l (18:34) Jailers: or “torturers” (Greek *basanistai*).

Chapter 19

1 Once Jesus had ended these sayings, he departed from Galilee and
went to the part of Judea that lies across the Jordan. 2 Great crowds
followed him, and he healed them there.
3 Some Pharisees came to him to test him. "Is it permissible," they
asked, "for a man to divorce his wife on any ground whatever?" 4 He
answered, "Have you not read that the Creator at the beginning made
them male and female,[a] 5 and said, 'For this reason a man will leave his
father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become
one flesh'?[b] 6 So they are no longer two, but one flesh. What God has
yoked together, then, no human being must separate." 7 They asked
him, "Then why did Moses order that a man give his wife a divorce
certificate and send her away?"[c] 8 He told them, "It was because your
hearts were hard that Moses allowed you to divorce your wives; but it
was not that way from the beginning. 9 I tell you, anyone who divorces
his wife, except for sexual immorality, and marries another commits
adultery."[d] 10 The disciples said to him, "If that is how things stand
between a man and his wife, it is better not to marry." 11 He answered,
"This saying is not for everyone to take in, but only for those who
are given it. 12 Some are eunuchs because they were born that way;
some were made eunuchs by other people; and some have renounced
marriage[e] for the sake of the kingdom of heaven. Whoever can take
this in should take it in."
13 Then little children were brought to him so that he might lay his
hands on them and pray. The disciples scolded those who brought
them, 14 but Jesus said, "Let the little children be, and do not stop them
from coming to me; for the kingdom of heaven belongs to such as
these." 15 He laid his hands on them and went on from there.
16 And now a man came up to him and asked, "Teacher, what good
deed must I do to gain eternal life?" 17 "Why are you asking me about
the good?" Jesus replied. "Only One is good.[f] If you wish to enter life,
keep the commandments." 18 "Which ones?" he asked. Jesus replied,
" 'You are not to murder, not to commit adultery, not to steal, and
not to give false testimony; 19 honor your father and mother;'[g] and,
'Love your neighbor as yourself.' "[h] 20 "All of those I have observed,"

the young man told him. “Where do I still fall short?” 21 Jesus said to
him, “If you want to be complete,[i] go and sell what you own and give
the money to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; then
come, follow me.” 22 When the young man heard this, he went away
grieving, for he had many possessions.
23 Then Jesus said to his disciples, “Amen, I tell you, it will be hard for
someone rich to enter the kingdom of heaven. 24 And again I say to
you, a camel could go through the eye of a needle[j] more easily than
a rich person could enter the kingdom of God.” 25 When the disciples
heard this, they were utterly astonished. “Who then can be saved?”
they asked. 26 Looking at them, Jesus said, “For human beings it is
impossible, but for God everything is possible.”[k]
27 Then Peter answered him, “We have given up everything and
followed you. What will we get?” 28 Jesus answered them, “Amen, I
tell you: at the world’s rebirth,[l] when the Son of Man sits upon the
throne of his glory, you who followed me will likewise sit on twelve
thrones and judge the twelve tribes of Israel. 29 And everyone who has
given up houses, brothers, sisters, father, mother,[m] children or fields
for the sake of my name will receive a hundred times as much[n] and
inherit eternal life. 30 Yet many now first will be last, and many now
last will be first.

Notes

- a (19:4) Gen 1:27; 5:2.
- b (19:5) Gen 2:24.
- c (19:7) Deut 24:1–4.
- d (19:9) Except for sexual unfaithfulness: Greek *porneia*, a broad term for sexual immorality, whose exact sense here is debated. Compare 5:32. Many manuscripts add, from 5:32, “and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery”; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and other witnesses, lacks it (WH prints it in the margin).
- e (19:12) Renounced marriage: literally “made themselves eunuchs.” Eunuchs were men who could not father children. Those who “made themselves eunuchs” are generally understood as those who chose to remain unmarried for the sake of the kingdom.
- f (19:17) Why are you asking me about the good? Only One is good: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus. Most later manuscripts assimilate

to Mark 10:17–18: “Good teacher … Why do you call me good? No one is good but One, that is, God.”

- g (19:19) Exod 20:12–16; Deut 5:16–20.
- h (19:19) Lev 19:18.
- i (19:21) Complete: or “perfect” (compare 5:48).
- j (19:24) A camel … the eye of a needle: a proverbial image of something impossible. Compare the rabbinic proverb of an elephant going through the eye of a needle.
- k (19:26) Compare Gen 18:14; Job 42:2; Zech 8:6.
- l (19:28) The world’s rebirth: Greek *palingenesia*, “new genesis” or “rebirth,” the renewal of the world at the end of the age.
- m (19:29) Mother: most manuscripts add “or wife”; the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and other witnesses, lacks it.
- n (19:29) Many times as much: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and a few other witnesses; most manuscripts read “a hundred times as much.”

Chapter 20

1 “For the kingdom of heaven is like a landowner who went out
at daybreak to hire laborers for his vineyard. 2 He agreed with the
laborers to pay them the usual day’s wage[a] and sent them into his
vineyard. 3 Going out again at about nine in the morning,[b] he saw
others standing idle in the marketplace, 4 and he said to them, ‘You too
go into the vineyard, and I will give you whatever is fair.’ So off they
went. 5 He went out again around noon and again around three in the
afternoon, and did the same. 6 About five o’clock in the afternoon he
went out again and found others standing around. He asked them,
‘Why are you standing here idle all day long?’ 7 ‘Because no one has
hired us,’ they answered. He told them, ‘You also go to the vineyard.’
8 When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his manager,
‘Call the laborers and pay them their wages, starting with the last
and ending with the first.’ 9 Those hired at about five o’clock came,
and each received a full day’s wage. 10 So when the first came, they
supposed they would receive more; but each of them, too, received
a day’s wage. 11 On receiving it, they began grumbling against the
landowner: 12 ‘These latecomers put in one hour, and you have made
them equal to us, who have borne the burden of the day and the
scorching heat.’ 13 But he answered one of them, ‘Friend, I am doing
you no wrong. Did you not agree with me on a day’s wage? 14 Take

what is yours and go. I choose to give this last man the same as I give
you. 15 Do I not have the right to do what I want with what is mine?
Are you envious because I am generous?'[c] 16 So the last will be first,
and the first last."[d]
17 As Jesus was going up to Jerusalem, he took the Twelve aside by
themselves, and on the road he said to them, 18 "Listen: we are going
up to Jerusalem, and the Son of Man will be handed over to the chief
priests and scribes. They will sentence him to death 19 and hand him
on to the Gentiles, who will make sport of him, whip him and crucify
him; and on the third day he will be raised up."
20 Then the mother of Zebedee's sons came to him with her sons,
bowing down and asking a favor of him. 21 "What would you like?"
he asked. She answered, "Give your word that in your kingdom these
two sons of mine will sit beside you, the one on your right and the
other on your left." 22 Jesus answered, "You do not know what you are
asking. Can you drink the cup[e] that I am about to drink?" "We can,"
they said.[f] 23 He told them, "You will drink my cup, yes; but the seats
at my right and left are not mine to give. They are for those for whom
my Father has made them ready."
24 When the other ten heard about this, they were indignant with the
two brothers. 25 But Jesus called them to him and said, "You know
that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and their great men
make them feel their authority. 26 It must not be like that among you.
Whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant, 27
and whoever wishes to be first among you must be your slave, 28 just
as the Son of Man did not come to be served but to serve, and to give
his life as a ransom[g] for many."
29 As they made their way out of Jericho,[h] a great crowd went along
with him. 30 Two blind men sitting by the roadside heard that Jesus
was passing and shouted, "Lord, Son of David, have pity on us!" 31 The
people scolded them and told them to hush, but they cried out even
more loudly, "Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us!" 32 Jesus came to
a halt and called out to them, "What would you have me do for you?"
33 "Lord," they answered, "we want our eyes opened." 34 Jesus was filled

with pity and touched their eyes, and at once their sight came back, and they followed him.

Notes

- a (20:2) The usual day's wage: literally "a denarius for the day." The denarius was a Roman silver coin, the normal daily pay of a laborer; so also in verses 9, 10 and 13.
- b (20:3) About nine in the morning: literally "about the third hour." The day was counted from sunrise (about 6 a.m.), so the sixth hour was about noon, the ninth about 3 p.m., and the eleventh (verses 6 and 9) about 5 p.m.
- c (20:15) Is your eye evil because I am good: an idiom. An "evil eye" means envy or stinginess (compare 6:23), so: "Are you envious because I am generous?"
- d (20:16) Many manuscripts add, from 22:14, "For many are called, but few are chosen"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks it.
- e (20:22) Cup: a figure for suffering appointed by God (compare 26:39; Isa 51:17; Jer 25:15).
- f (20:22) Many manuscripts add, from Mark 10:38–39, "or be baptized with the baptism with which I am baptized," and in verse 23 "and be baptized with the baptism with which I am baptized"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and others, lacks both.
- g (20:28) Ransom: Greek *lytron*, the price paid to free a slave or captive. Compare Isa 53:10–12.
- h (20:29) Jericho: an ancient city near the Jordan, about 15 miles (24 km) northeast of Jerusalem, rebuilt by Herod the Great. The name may mean "moon city" or "fragrant."

Chapter 21

1 As they approached Jerusalem and reached Bethphage[a] on the
Mount of Olives,[b] Jesus dispatched two of his disciples 2 and told them,
"Go to the village ahead of you. Right when you enter it, you will find
a tied donkey and a colt with her. Untie them and bring them to me.
3 And if anyone says anything to you, you shall say, 'The Lord needs
them,' and he will send them at once." 4 All this happened so that the
word spoken by the prophet might be fulfilled: 5 "Say to the daughter
of Zion,[c] 'See, your king is coming to you, gentle, and riding on a
donkey, on a colt, the foal of a beast of burden.' "[d] 6 The disciples went
and did as Jesus had directed them. 7 They led the donkey and the
colt back, laid their cloaks over them, and he took his seat on them.[e] 8
Very many in the crowd laid their own cloaks on the road, and others
were cutting branches off the trees and laying them on the road. 9 The

crowds that went ahead of him and those that followed kept shouting,
"Hosanna[f] to the Son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name
of the Lord![g] Hosanna in the highest heaven!" 10 When he entered
Jerusalem, the whole city was shaken. "Who is this?" people asked.
11 The crowds answered, "This is the prophet Jesus, from Nazareth
in Galilee."
12 Jesus entered the temple[h] and threw out everyone doing business
there, sellers and buyers alike; he tipped over the money changers'
tables and the chairs of the dove sellers.[i] 13 He said to them, "It is
written, 'My house shall be called a house of prayer,'[j] but you are
making it a den of robbers."[k]
14 Blind and lame people came to him in the temple, and he healed
them. 15 But the chief priests and the scribes were incensed when they
saw the marvels he performed and heard the children in the temple
calling out, "Hosanna to the Son of David!" 16 and asked him, "Do you
hear what they are saying?" Jesus answered, "Yes. Have you never
read: 'From the mouths of children and infants you have prepared
praise'?"[l] 17 And leaving them, he went out of the city to Bethany[m]
and spent the night there.
18 Early in the morning, as he was going back to the city, he was
hungry. 19 Seeing a fig tree by the road, he went to it and found nothing
on it but leaves. He said to it, "May fruit never come from you again!"
And the fig tree withered at once. 20 The disciples were astonished at
the sight. "How did the fig tree dry up all at once?" they asked. 21 Jesus
said in reply, "Amen, I tell you, if you have faith and are not of two
minds, you will do not only what I did to the fig tree; you could even
tell this mountain, 'Up with you, and into the sea!' and so it would
be. 22 And whatever you ask for in prayer, believing, you will receive."
23 When he had entered the temple, the chief priests and the elders
of the people came to him as he was teaching and said, "By what
authority are you doing these things, and who gave you this author-
ity?" 24 Jesus replied, "I have one question for you as well. Answer me,
and I will tell you on what authority I act as I do. 25 John's baptism:
where did it come from? From heaven, or from human beings?" They
argued it out among themselves: "If we say, 'From heaven,' he will

say to us, ‘Why then did you not believe him?’ 26 And if we say, ‘Of
human origin,’ we have the people to fear, since everyone takes John
for a prophet.” 27 So their answer to Jesus was, “We cannot tell.” He in
turn said to them, “Then neither am I telling you on what authority
I act as I do.
28 “Now tell me what you think. A man who had two sons went to the
first and said, ‘My son, go and put in a day’s work in the vineyard.’
29 ‘I am going, sir,’ he replied; but he never went. 30 The father went
to the second son and said the same thing. He answered, ‘I will not,’
but afterward he changed his mind and went. 31 Which of the two did
what his father wanted?” “The second,”[n] they answered. Jesus said to
them, “Amen, I tell you, tax collectors and prostitutes are entering the
kingdom of God ahead of you. 32 For John came to you showing the
way of righteousness, and you put no faith in him; yet tax collectors
and prostitutes put their faith in him. You saw that, and even so you
did not repent afterward and believe him.
33 “Hear another parable. A certain householder planted a vineyard,
hedged it about, hollowed out a winepress in it and put up a tower.[o]
Then he rented it out to growers and left the country. 34 As the season
of fruit came near, he sent his slaves to the growers to receive his
share of the crop. 35 But the growers seized his slaves; one they beat,
another they killed, another they stoned. 36 He sent still other servants,
a larger group than before, and the tenants treated these in the same
way. 37 Last of all he sent them his son. ‘My son they will respect,’ he
said. 38 But when the growers saw the son, they said to one another,
‘This is the heir. Come, let us kill him and seize his inheritance.’ 39
And they took him, threw him out of the vineyard, and killed him. 40
So when the owner of the vineyard comes, what will he do to those
growers?” 41 They answered, “He will put those villains to a miserable
death and rent the vineyard out to other growers, who will hand over
his share of the fruit when it is due.” 42 Jesus said to them, “Did you
never read in the Scriptures, ‘The stone the builders threw aside has
been made the head of the corner;[p] this is the Lord’s doing, and a
wonder in our eyes’?[q] 43 That is why I say to you that God’s kingdom
will be taken from you and handed to a nation that yields its fruit.

44 [Anyone who falls on this stone will be shattered, and anyone on
whom it falls will be ground to powder.][r] 45 Hearing his parables, the
chief priests and the Pharisees knew that he was talking about them.
46 They were eager to lay hands on him, but were afraid of the crowds,
who held him to be a prophet.

Notes

- a (21:1) Bethphage: "house of unripe figs," a village on the Mount of Olives near Bethany.
- b (21:1) Mount of Olives: the ridge east of Jerusalem across the Kidron Valley. Compare Zech 14:4.
- c (21:5) Daughter of Zion: a poetic name for Jerusalem and its people. *Zion* was the hill of the city of David.
- d (21:5) Isa 62:11; Zech 9:9.
- e (21:7) He sat on them: that is, on the cloaks.
- f (21:9) Hosanna: from Hebrew *hoshi'ah na'*, "save, please!" (Ps 118:25), which by this time had become a shout of praise.
- g (21:9) Ps 118:26. "The Lord" translates *kyrios*, which in the Hebrew is the divine name Yahweh.
- h (21:12) The temple: Greek *hieron*, the whole temple complex. The selling and money changing took place in the outer court, the Court of the Gentiles. Many manuscripts read "the temple of God"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, reads "the temple."
- i (21:12) Money changers … doves: the temple tax had to be paid in Tyrian silver, so other coins were exchanged; doves were the offering of the poor (Lev 5:7; 12:8).
- j (21:13) Isa 56:7.
- k (21:13) Jer 7:11.
- l (21:16) Ps 8:2 (8:3 in Hebrew), quoted in the wording of the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew reads "you have established strength."
- m (21:17) Bethany: a village about 2 miles (3 km) from Jerusalem on the far side of the Mount of Olives. The name may mean "house of the poor" or "house of Ananiah."
- n (21:31) The second: literally "the latter." The manuscripts differ widely in verses 29–31. Many read the order: the first son says "I will not" but goes, and the second says "I will, sir" but does not go, with the answer "the first." The Westcott–Hort text follows Vaticanus and others in the order given here. Codex Bezae (D) has the father's will done by the son who says no, yet answers "the latter," which makes little sense. Scholarly review recommended.
- o (21:33) Isa 5:1–2.
- p (21:42) The head of the corner: either the foundation stone at a corner or the capstone.
- q (21:42) Ps 118:22–23. "The Lord" is Yahweh in the Hebrew.

- r (21:44) Verse 44 is absent from Codex Bezae (D), some Old Latin manuscripts, and early writers, and may have been added from Luke 20:18. It is present in Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, and the Westcott–Hort text prints it in single brackets as doubtful. It is printed here in brackets. Compare Isa 8:14–15; Dan 2:34–35, 44–45.

Chapter 22

1 Once more Jesus spoke to them in parables. He said: 2 "Here is a
picture of the kingdom of heaven: a king held a marriage feast in
honor of his son. 3 He dispatched his slaves to call the guests who
had been invited to the feast, but they refused to come. 4 Then he
sent other slaves, telling them, 'Say to the invited guests: Look, my
dinner is prepared; my oxen and fattened cattle are slaughtered, and
everything stands ready. Come to the wedding.' 5 But they shrugged
it off and went their ways, this one to his farm and that one to his
business, 6 while the rest laid hold of his slaves, mistreated them, and
killed them. 7 The king was furious. He sent his troops, destroyed
those murderers, and set their city on fire. 8 Then he said to his slaves,
'The wedding is ready, but the invited guests did not deserve it. 9 So
go out to where the roads leave the city[a] and invite to the wedding
as many as you can find.' 10 Out went those slaves into the roads and
brought in everyone they came across, bad and good alike, and the
wedding hall was crowded with guests.
11 "When the king came in to view the guests, he caught sight of a
man there who had on no wedding garment. 12 'My friend,' he asked,
'how did you get in here without wedding clothes?' The man had no
answer. 13 Then the king told his attendants, 'Bind his hands and feet
and throw him out into the darkness, where there will be weeping
and grinding of teeth.' 14 For many are called, but few are chosen."
15 Then the Pharisees went and laid plans to trap him in what he said.
16 They sent their disciples to him along with the Herodians,[b] who
said, "Teacher, we know that you are truthful and teach the way of
God in truth, and you defer to no one, for you pay no regard to a
person's standing. 17 So give us your opinion: is it lawful to pay the
poll tax[c] to Caesar, or not?" 18 Jesus saw through their malice and said,
"Hypocrites! Why are you putting me to the test? 19 Let me see the
coin you pay the tax with." And they brought him a silver coin.[d] 20

He asked them, “Whose likeness is this, and whose inscription?” 21
“Caesar’s,” they told him. He said to them, “Then pay to Caesar what
belongs to Caesar, and pay to God what belongs to God.” 22 Hearing
this, they were astonished; and leaving him, they departed.
23 That same day some Sadducees came to him, who say there is no
resurrection,[e] and they put a question to him: 24 “Teacher, Moses said,
‘If a man dies without children, his brother is to marry the widow and
raise up offspring for his brother.’[f] 25 Now there were seven brothers
among us. The first married and died, and having no offspring, he left
his wife to his brother. 26 So too the second and the third, all the way to
the seventh. 27 Last of all the woman died. 28 In the resurrection, then,
whose wife will she be of the seven? For they all had her.” 29 Jesus
answered them, “You are going astray, because you know neither the
Scriptures nor the power of God. 30 In the resurrection people neither
marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels in heaven. 31 And
as for the resurrection of the dead, have you not read what God said
to you: 32 ‘I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of
Jacob’?[g] He is not a God of dead people, but of living ones.” 33 When
the crowds heard this, they were astounded at his teaching.
34 When the Pharisees heard that he had silenced the Sadducees, they
gathered together, 35 and a lawyer[h] among them tried to trip him up
by asking, 36 “Teacher, which commandment in the Law is greatest?”
37 Jesus said to him, “ ‘Love the Lord your God with all your heart,
with all your soul, and with all your mind.’[i] 38 This is the great and
first commandment. 39 And there is a second resembling it: ‘You shall
love your neighbor as yourself.’[j] 40 On these two commandments the
whole Law and the Prophets hang.”
41 While the Pharisees were gathered together, Jesus asked them a
question: 42 “How do you see the Messiah? Whose descendant is he?”
“David’s,” they answered. 43 He asked them, “Then how can David,
inspired by the Spirit, call him Lord? For he says, 44 ‘The Lord said to
my Lord, Sit at my right hand, until I put your enemies under your
feet’?[k] 45 If, then, David calls him Lord, in what sense is he David’s
son?” 46 No one was able to give him a word in answer, and from that
day no one dared to question him any further.

Notes

- a (22:9) Where the roads leave the city: literally "the outlets of the roads," where the city streets ran out into the open country, or the crossroads.
- b (22:16) Herodians: supporters of the dynasty of Herod, and so of cooperation with Rome.
- c (22:17) Poll tax: Greek *kēnsos* (Latin *census*), the head tax paid by every adult to Rome, bitterly resented by many Jews.
- d (22:19) A silver coin: literally "a denarius," a Roman silver coin worth a day's wage, bearing the image of the emperor Tiberius and an inscription calling him son of the divine Augustus.
- e (22:23) Sadducees: see 3:7 note. They accepted only the Law of Moses as binding and denied a future resurrection (Acts 23:8).
- f (22:24) Deut 25:5–6; compare Gen 38:8. This is the custom of "levirate" marriage.
- g (22:32) Exod 3:6, 15.
- h (22:35) A lawyer: that is, an expert in the Law of Moses; Greek *nomikos*, a specialist in the Law of Moses, much the same as a scribe. A few witnesses omit the word.
- i (22:37) Deut 6:5, where "the Lord" is Yahweh in the Hebrew. The Hebrew has "heart ... soul ... strength"; Matthew gives "mind" for the last.
- j (22:39) Lev 19:18.
- k (22:44) Ps 110:1. In the Hebrew, "The Lord said" is "Yahweh said"; "my Lord" is *adoni*, "my master." Many manuscripts read "a footstool for your feet," as in the Greek Old Testament.

Chapter 23

1 Then Jesus addressed the crowds and his disciples: 2 "The scribes and
the Pharisees sit in the chair of Moses.[a] 3 So do whatever they tell you,
and keep it; but do not imitate their actions, for they talk but do not
act. 4 They tie up heavy loads and pile them on people's shoulders, but
they themselves will not lift a finger to shift them. 5 All their deeds
they do to be noticed by others; they make their phylacteries[b] broad
and the tassels on their garments long; 6 they love the places of honor
at banquets and the front seats in the synagogues, 7 and being greeted
respectfully in the marketplaces, and being called Rabbi[c] by people.
8 You, though, are not to be addressed as Rabbi; your teacher is One,
and all of you are brothers. 9 And call no one on earth your father,
for you have one Father, the heavenly one. 10 Nor must you be called
leaders, for you have one leader, the Messiah. 11 The greatest among

you will be your servant. 12 Whoever exalts himself will be humbled,
and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.
13 "Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You lock people out
of the kingdom of heaven. You do not enter yourselves, and when
others are going in, you will not let them. 14 [d] 15 "Woe to you, scribes
and Pharisees, hypocrites! You travel over sea and dry land to make
a single convert,[e] and when he becomes one, you make him twice as
much a son of Gehenna as yourselves.
16 "Woe to you, blind guides, who say, 'If anyone swears by the
sanctuary,[f] it means nothing; but if anyone swears by the gold of the
sanctuary, he is bound by his oath.' 17 Blind fools! Which is greater,
the gold, or the sanctuary that made the gold sacred? 18 And you say,
'If anyone swears by the altar, it means nothing; but if anyone swears
by the gift that is on it, he is bound.' 19 Blind people! Which is greater,
the gift, or the altar that makes the gift sacred? 20 So whoever swears
by the altar swears by it and by everything on it; 21 and to swear by
the sanctuary is to swear by it and by the one who lives in it; 22 and
whoever swears by heaven swears by the throne of God and by him
who sits on it.
23 "How terrible for you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You give
a tenth of your mint, dill and cumin,[g] but you have ignored the more
important matters of the Law: justice, mercy and faithfulness. You
should have done these things without ignoring the others. 24 Blind
guides! You strain out a gnat and gulp down a camel![h]
25 "Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You clean the
outside of the cup and the dish, but inside they are full of plunder
and self-indulgence. 26 Blind Pharisee! First clean the inside of the cup
[and the dish],[i] so that the outside of it may become clean as well.
27 "Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You resemble tombs
coated with whitewash,[j] handsome to look at from outside, but full
within of the bones of the dead and of all that is unclean. 28 In the
same way you too look righteous to people on the outside, but inside
you are full of hypocrisy and lawlessness.
29 "How terrible for you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You build
tombs for the prophets and decorate the graves of the righteous, 30 and

you say, ‘If we had lived in the time of our ancestors, we would never
have taken part with them in killing the prophets.’ 31 So you testify
against yourselves that you are the sons of those who murdered the
prophets. 32 Go on, then, fill up the measure your fathers began! 33 You
snakes, you brood of vipers, how will you escape being sentenced
to Gehenna? 34 For this reason, look, I am sending you prophets and
wise men and scribes. Some of them you will kill and crucify, and
some you will flog in your synagogues and hunt from town to town;
35 so that upon you may come all the righteous blood shed on the
earth, from the blood of righteous Abel to the blood of Zechariah
son of Barachiah,[k] whom you murdered between the sanctuary and
the altar. 36 Amen, I tell you, all these things will come upon this
generation.
37 “Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets and stones
those who are sent to her! How often have I longed to gather your
children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and
you were not willing. 38 Look, your house is left to you.[l] 39 For I tell
you, you will not see me from now on until you say, ‘Blessed is he
who comes in the name of the Lord.’ ”[m]

Notes

- a (23:2) The chair of Moses: the seat of authority to teach and interpret the Law. Synagogues had a stone seat of this name.
- b (23:5) Phylacteries: small leather boxes containing passages of Scripture (Exod 13:1–16; Deut 6:4–9; 11:13–21), worn on the forehead and arm during prayer (compare Deut 6:8). Tassels: see Num 15:38–39 and 9:20 note.
- c (23:7) Rabbi: Hebrew/Aramaic for “my great one,” “my master,” used as a title of respect for a teacher.
- d (23:14) The Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts (including Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Bezae and others) do not include verse 14; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Many later manuscripts add, from Mark 12:40 and Luke 20:47 (and some place it before verse 13), “Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you devour widows’ houses and for a pretense make long prayers; therefore you will receive the greater condemnation.”
- e (23:15) Convert: Greek *prosēlytos*, a Gentile who had accepted circumcision and the Law of Moses.
- f (23:16) Sanctuary: Greek *naos*, the temple building itself, as distinct from the whole complex (*hieron*); also in verses 17, 21 and 35.

- g (23:23) Mint and dill and cumin: garden herbs. The Law required a tenth of produce (Lev 27:30; Deut 14:22–23); the Pharisees applied it even to small herbs.
- h (23:24) Gnat … camel: a joke. Both were unclean animals (Lev 11:4, 20–23); in Aramaic the words sound alike (*qalma*, *gamla*).
- i (23:26) And the dish: printed in brackets in the Westcott–Hort text as doubtful; Codex Bezae and a few other witnesses omit it.
- j (23:27) Whitewashed tombs: tombs were whitewashed so that people would not touch them unawares and become ritually unclean (Num 19:16).
- k (23:35) Abel … Zechariah: Abel is the first murder victim in the Bible (Gen 4:8), and Zechariah son of Jehoiada the last in the Hebrew order of the books, which ends with Chronicles (2 Chr 24:20–22). Matthew's "son of Barachiah" may reflect the prophet Zechariah (Zech 1:1). Sinaiticus (first hand) omits "son of Barachiah." *Abel* means "breath," "vapor"; *Zechariah* means "Yahweh remembers."
- l (23:38) Left to you: many manuscripts add "desolate," as does the Westcott–Hort margin; Vaticanus and a few others lack it. Compare Jer 12:7; 22:5.
- m (23:39) Ps 118:26, where "the Lord" is Yahweh in the Hebrew.

Chapter 24

1 As Jesus came out of the temple and was going on his way, his
disciples approached to direct his attention to the temple buildings. 2
He replied, "You see all this, do you not? Amen, I tell you, here not one
stone will be left standing on another; every stone will be torn down."
3 While he was seated on the Mount of Olives, the disciples came
to him by themselves. "Tell us," they said, "when is this to be, and
what sign will mark your coming[a] and the close of the age?" 4 Jesus
answered them, "See that no one leads you astray. 5 Many will come
using my name and claiming, 'I am the Messiah,' and they will deceive
many. 6 You will hear of wars and rumors of wars. See that you are not
alarmed; these things must happen, but the end is not yet. 7 Nation
will rise against nation and kingdom against kingdom,[b] and there will
be famines and earthquakes in one place after another. 8 All this is
only the first of the labor pains.[c]
9 "Then they will hand you over to be tormented and will kill you,
and you will be hated by all nations because of my name. 10 At that
time many will be tripped up; they will hand each other over and hate
each other. 11 Many false prophets will arise and lead many astray. 12
And because lawlessness will increase, the love of most people will
grow cold. 13 But whoever endures to the end will be saved. 14 And this

good news of the kingdom will be proclaimed throughout the whole inhabited world as a testimony to all the nations, and then the end will come.
15 “So when you see the desolating abomination[d] spoken of by Daniel the prophet standing in the holy place (let the reader understand), 16 then let those who are in Judea escape into the mountains. 17 Anyone on the housetop must not go down to take anything out of his house, 18 and anyone in the field must not turn back to fetch his cloak. 19 How dreadful it will be in those days for expectant mothers and for women with nursing babies! 20 Pray that your flight may not come in winter or on a Sabbath. 21 For then there will be great distress, such as has not been from the beginning of the world until now, and never will be again.[e] 22 Unless those days were shortened, no living thing would be rescued; but for the elect’s sake those days will be shortened. 23 At that time, if someone tells you, ‘The Messiah is here!’ or ‘He is over there!’ put no faith in it. 24 For false messiahs and false prophets will arise and produce great signs and wonders, so as to lead astray, if possible, even the chosen. 25 There, I have told you beforehand. 26 So if people tell you, ‘He is out in the wilderness,’ stay where you are; if they say, ‘He is in the back rooms,’ put no faith in it. 27 Like lightning that flashes out of the east and lights up the sky to the west, so the coming of the Son of Man will be. 28 Where the corpse lies, the vultures[f] flock together.
29 “Immediately after the distress of those days the sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light, and the stars will fall from the sky, and the powers of the heavens will be shaken.[g] 30 Then the sign of the Son of Man will appear in heaven, and then all the tribes of the earth will mourn,[h] and they will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and great glory.[i] 31 With a great trumpet blast[j] he will send forth his angels, and they will gather his elect from the four winds, from one edge of the heavens to the other.
32 “Let the fig tree teach you its lesson. When its branch turns soft and its leaves sprout, you recognize that summer is close. 33 In the same way, when you see all this happening, recognize that he is close, right at the door. 34 Amen, I tell you, this generation will not pass away

until all these things take place. 35 Heaven and earth will pass away,
but my words will never pass away.
36 "As for that day and hour, nobody knows it, not the angels of heaven,
not the Son,[k] only the Father. 37 For as the days of Noah were, so will be
the coming of the Son of Man. 38 For as in those days before the flood
they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until
the day Noah entered the ark, 39 and they were unaware until the flood
came and carried every one of them off; that is how the Son of Man's
coming will be.[l] 40 Then two men will be in the field; one is taken and
one is left. 41 Two women will be grinding at the mill; one is taken and
one is left. 42 Stay alert, therefore, since you cannot know the day of
your Lord's coming. 43 Understand this: if the householder had known
in which part of the night[m] the thief would come, he would have kept
watch and not allowed his house to be dug through. 44 That is why
you also must stand ready; the Son of Man will come at an hour when
you are not looking for him.
45 "Who, then, is the trustworthy and prudent slave, set by his master
over the household staff to give them their rations at the right time? 46
Happy that slave, if his master finds him so engaged when he arrives!
47 Amen, I tell you, his master will make him steward of everything
he owns. 48 But suppose that slave is wicked and thinks, 'My master is
taking his time,' 49 and he starts beating his fellow slaves and feasting
and drinking with drunkards; 50 then that slave's master will arrive
on a day he does not foresee and at an hour he is not aware of, 51 and
cut him to pieces,[n] and give him a place among the hypocrites, where
there will be weeping and grinding of teeth.

Notes

- a (24:3) Coming: Greek *parousia*, "presence," "arrival," used of the visit of a king or high official; also in verses 27, 37 and 39.
- b (24:7) Compare Isa 19:2; 2 Chr 15:6.
- c (24:8) Labor pains: a common image for the sufferings expected to come before the age to come.
- d (24:15) The desolating abomination: traditionally "the abomination of desolation," a sacrilege that makes the holy place desolate. Dan 9:27; 11:31; 12:11. Daniel refers to the pagan altar set up in the temple by Antiochus IV in 167 BC (1 Macc 1:54).

- e (24:21) Compare Dan 12:1; Joel 2:2.
- f (24:28) Vultures: Greek *aetoi*, usually "eagles," but here carrion birds.
- g (24:29) Isa 13:10; 34:4; compare Ezek 32:7; Joel 2:10.
- h (24:30) Compare Zech 12:10–14.
- i (24:30) Dan 7:13–14.
- j (24:31) A great trumpet blast: compare Isa 27:13. Some manuscripts read "a trumpet and a loud sound."
- k (24:36) Nor the Son: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus (first hand), Bezae and others; most later manuscripts lack these words, perhaps because they seemed to limit the Son's knowledge. Compare Mark 13:32.
- l (24:39) Gen 6:5–7:23.
- m (24:43) In which part of the night: literally "in which watch." The night was divided into watches (see 14:25 note).
- n (24:51) Cut him in pieces: or "punish him severely."

Chapter 25

1 "At that time the kingdom of heaven will be compared to ten young
bridesmaids[a] who took their lamps and set out to meet the groom. 2
Five of them were foolish, and five were sensible. 3 The foolish ones
took their lamps but brought no oil along; 4 the sensible ones took
flasks of oil with their lamps. 5 Since the bridegroom was delayed,
they all nodded off and slept. 6 But at midnight a shout rang out:
'The bridegroom is here! Come out to meet him!' 7 Then all those
young women woke and trimmed their lamps. 8 The foolish ones said
to the sensible ones, 'Let us have some of your oil; our lamps are
going out.' 9 But the sensible ones answered, 'No; there may not be
enough for both us and you. Go instead to the dealers and buy some
for yourselves.' 10 While they were away buying it, the bridegroom
arrived, and those who were ready went in with him to the wedding
feast, and the door was shut. 11 Later the other young women came
too. 'Sir, sir,' they said, 'open up for us!' 12 But he answered, 'Amen,
I say to you, you are strangers to me.' 13 Keep watch, then, for you
know neither the day nor the hour.[b]
14 "It is like a man who was going abroad. He summoned his slaves and
placed his wealth in their hands. 15 To one he gave five bags of silver,[c]
to another two, to another one, each according to his own capability;
and he went away. At once 16 the one who had received the five bags

went and put them to work, and gained five more. 17 In the same way
the one with the two gained two more. 18 But the slave who had been
given one bag went away and dug in the earth and buried his master's
money there. 19 After a long time the master of those slaves came back
and settled accounts with them. 20 The one who had received the five
bags came forward bringing five more. 'Sir,' he said, 'you entrusted
five bags of silver to me; see, I have gained five more.' 21 His master
said, 'Excellent, good and faithful servant! You were trustworthy with
a little, so I will put you in charge of much. Come and share your
master's happiness.' 22 The one with the two bags also came forward.
'Sir,' he said, 'you entrusted two bags to me; see, I have gained two
more.' 23 His master said, 'Excellent, good and faithful servant! You
were trustworthy with a little, so I will put you in charge of much.
Come and share your master's happiness.' 24 Then the one who had
received the single bag came forward too. 'Sir,' he said, 'I knew you to
be a hard man, reaping where you did not sow and gathering where
you did not scatter seed. 25 I was frightened, so I went off and buried
your silver in the earth. There it is; take back what belongs to you.'
26 But his master answered, 'You wicked, lazy servant! You say you
knew that I harvest where I never planted and gather where I never
scattered seed? 27 Then you ought to have deposited my money with
the bankers, and on my return I would have got back what was mine
with interest. 28 Take the bag from him, then, and give it to the one
who has ten. 29 To all who have, more will be given, until they have
plenty; but those who have nothing will lose even what they have.
30 And as for this good-for-nothing slave, throw him out into the
darkness outside, where people will weep and grind their teeth.'
31 "When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with
him, then he will sit on his glorious throne.[d] 32 All the nations will be
gathered before him, and he will separate them one from another, as a
shepherd separates the sheep from the goats. 33 He will place the sheep
on his right and the goats on his left. 34 Then the King will say to those
at his right, 'Come, you whom my Father has blessed, take possession
of the kingdom prepared for you since the world was founded. 35 For
I was hungry and you gave me food; I was thirsty and you gave me

drink; I was a stranger and you took me in; 36 I was naked and you clothed me; I was sick and you looked after me; I was in prison and you came to me.' 37 Then the righteous will answer him, 'Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you drink? 38 When did we see you a stranger and take you in, or naked and clothe you? 39 When did we see you sick or in prison and come to you?' 40 And the King will answer them, 'Amen, I tell you, whenever you did it for one of the least of these brothers of mine, you did it for me.'
41 "Then he will say to those at his left, 'Go away from me, you who are cursed, into the everlasting fire prepared for the devil and his angels.
42 For I was hungry and you gave me no food; I was thirsty and you gave me no drink; 43 I was a stranger and you did not welcome me in; I was naked and you gave me no clothes; I was sick and in prison and you did not visit me.' 44 Then they too will answer, 'Lord, when did we see you hungry or thirsty or a stranger or naked or sick or in prison, and did not serve you?' 45 He will reply, 'Amen, I tell you, every time you failed to do it for one of these, even the least, you failed to do it for me.' 46 And these will go away into everlasting punishment, but the righteous into everlasting life."[e]

Notes

- a (25:1) Young bridesmaids: literally "virgins," unmarried girls who would escort the bridegroom to the wedding feast with torches or lamps.
- b (25:13) Many manuscripts add "in which the Son of Man is coming"; the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts, lacks it.
- c (25:15) Bags of silver: literally "talents"; so throughout this parable. A talent was a large weight of silver, about 75 pounds (34 kg), worth about 6,000 days' wages for a laborer, nearly twenty years' pay. Even the one bag entrusted to the third slave was a fortune. (From this parable the English word *talent* came to mean a natural gift.)
- d (25:31) Compare Zech 14:5; Dan 7:9–14.
- e (25:46) Compare Dan 12:2.

Chapter 26

1 When Jesus had brought all these sayings to an end, he said to his disciples, 2 "You know that the Passover[a] is two days away, and the Son of Man will be handed over to be crucified."

3 Then the chief priests and the elders of the people met together in
the courtyard of the high priest, whose name was Caiaphas,[b] 4 and
they laid plans to seize Jesus by cunning and put him to death. 5 Yet
they said, "It must not be at the feast, or the people may riot."
6 While Jesus was staying in Bethany at the home of Simon, known as
the leper,[c] 7 a woman approached him with an alabaster jar[d] of very
expensive perfume, and as he was reclining at table she poured it
over his head. 8 The disciples were indignant when they saw it. "What
is the point of this waste?" they said. 9 "That perfume might have
fetched a high price,[e] and the proceeds could have gone to the poor."
10 Jesus was aware of it and said to them, "Why are you troubling
the woman? It is a beautiful thing she has done for me. 11 The poor
you have with you always,[f] but me you will not always have. 12 When
she poured this ointment over my body, she did it to make me ready
for burial. 13 Amen, I tell you, wherever this gospel is preached in the
whole world, what she has done will be told in memory of her."
14 It was then that one of the Twelve, called Judas Iscariot, went off
to the chief priests 15 and said, "What are you willing to give me if
I hand him over to you?" They weighed out thirty silver coins[g] for
him. 16 And from then on he kept looking for a good opportunity to
betray him.
17 On the first day of the festival of Unleavened Bread[h] the disciples
came to Jesus and asked, "Where would you like us to make prepa-
rations for you to eat the Passover?" 18 He told them, "Go into the
city to So-and-so and say to him, 'The Teacher says: My appointed
time is at hand. I mean to keep the Passover with my disciples at your
house.' " 19 The disciples did just as Jesus had instructed them, and
they prepared the Passover.
20 When evening came, he took his place at table with the Twelve.[i] 21
While they were at the meal, he said, "Amen, I tell you, one of you
is going to betray me." 22 They were deeply distressed, and one after
another they began to ask him, "Surely not I, Lord?" 23 He answered,
"He who dipped his hand in the dish together with me, he will betray
me. 24 The Son of Man goes his way as it is written of him, but alas
for that man by whom the Son of Man is betrayed! It would have

been better for that man if he had never been born." 25 Judas, who was betraying him, answered, "Surely not I, Rabbi?" He said to him, "You have said it."[j]

26 During the meal, Jesus took a loaf of bread, gave thanks, broke it, and gave it to his disciples. "Take it and eat," he said, "this is my body." 27 And taking a cup and giving thanks, he gave it to them, saying, "Drink from it, every one of you; 28 for this is my blood of the covenant,[k] poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins. 29 I tell you, I will not drink of this fruit of the vine again until that day when I drink it new with you in my Father's kingdom." 30 And after singing the hymn,[l] they went out to the Mount of Olives.

31 Then Jesus said to them, "This very night all of you will stumble because of me, for it is written, 'I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep of the flock will be scattered.'[m] 32 But once I am raised up, I will lead the way before you into Galilee." 33 Peter answered him, "Though all the others stumble because of you, I will never stumble." 34 Jesus said to him, "Amen, I tell you, tonight, before the rooster crows, you will deny me three times." 35 "Even if I must die along with you," Peter told him, "disown you I will not!" Every one of the disciples said the same.

36 Then Jesus came with them to a plot of ground named Gethsemane,[n] and he told the disciples, "Stay sitting here while I go yonder to pray." 37 He took with him Peter and the two sons of Zebedee, and he began to be grieved and deeply troubled. 38 And he told them, "My soul is ringed about with grief, enough to kill me.[o] Remain here and keep awake with me." 39 He went on a little farther and fell facedown, praying, "My Father, if it can be, take this cup from me. Yet let your wish be done, not mine." 40 Then he came to the disciples and found them sleeping. He said to Peter, "So, were you not able to keep watch with me for one hour? 41 Keep watch and pray that you may not come into testing. The spirit is eager, but the flesh is weak." 42 He went away again, a second time, and prayed, "My Father, if this cup cannot be taken from me unless I drink it, then let your will be done." 43 And coming again he found them sleeping, for their eyes were heavy. 44 So leaving them again, he went away and prayed a third time, saying the

same words once more. 45 Then he came to the disciples and said to them, "Are you still sleeping and resting?[p] Look, the hour has come near, and the Son of Man is being handed over into the hands of sinners. 46 Get up, let us go. Look, my betrayer has come near."
47 While he was still speaking, Judas, one of the Twelve, arrived, and with him a large crowd with swords and clubs, from the chief priests and elders of the people. 48 The betrayer had given them a sign: "The one I kiss is the man; seize him." 49 He went straight up to Jesus and said, "Greetings, Rabbi!" and kissed him warmly. 50 "Friend," Jesus said to him, "do what you are here to do."[q] Then the others stepped forward, laid hold of Jesus and arrested him. 51 Just then one of those who were with Jesus reached for his sword, pulled it out, and struck the high priest's servant, cutting off his ear. 52 Jesus told him, "Return your sword to its sheath. Those who reach for the sword will die by the sword. 53 Or do you suppose I could not call on my Father, and he would immediately send me upward of twelve legions[r] of angels? 54 But then how could the Scriptures come true, that this is how it has to be?" 55 At that time Jesus said to the crowds, "Am I a bandit, that you have come out with swords and clubs to take me? Every day I sat teaching in the temple, and you never laid a hand on me. 56 But all this has taken place so that the writings of the prophets might be fulfilled." Then all the disciples deserted him and fled.
57 Those who had seized Jesus led him away to Caiaphas the high priest, where the scribes and the elders had gathered. 58 Peter followed at a distance as far as the courtyard of the high priest. Once inside, he sat down with the guards to see how things would turn out. 59 Now the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin[s] were seeking false testimony against Jesus so that they might put him to death, 60 but found none, even though many false witnesses stepped up. Finally two stepped up 61 and said, "This man said, 'I am able to destroy the sanctuary of God and to build it in three days.' "
62 The high priest stood up and said to him, "Have you no answer? What is this that these men are testifying against you?" 63 Jesus, however, remained silent. The high priest said to him, "By the living God I place you under oath: tell us, are you the Messiah, the Son of God?" 64 Jesus said to him, "You have

said it. But I tell you, from now on you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of the Power[t] and coming on the clouds of heaven."[u]
65 At that the high priest ripped his clothes[v] and said, "Blasphemy!
What further need do we have of witnesses? Here and now you have
heard his blasphemy. 66 What is your verdict?" They answered, "He
deserves death." 67 Then they spat in his face and struck him with their
fists; and some slapped him, 68 and saying, "Messiah, prophesy for us:
who struck you?"
69 Meanwhile Peter was sitting outside in the courtyard. A servant girl
came up to him and said, "You too were with Jesus the Galilean." 70
But he denied it in front of them all, saying, "I do not know what you
are talking about." 71 As he went out to the gateway, another servant
girl saw him and said to the people there, "This man was with Jesus
of Nazareth." 72 And again he denied it, with an oath: "I do not know
the man!" 73 After a little while the bystanders came over and said to
Peter, "You are certainly one of them; your accent gives you away."[w]
74 Then he began to call down curses and to swear, "I do not know the
man!" And at once a rooster crowed. 75 Peter remembered what Jesus
had said: "Before a rooster crows, you will deny me three times." He
went out and wept bitter tears.

Notes

- a (26:2) Passover: the spring festival recalling Israel's deliverance from Egypt (Exod 12), celebrated on the 14th–15th of Nisan, followed by the seven-day festival of Unleavened Bread.
- b (26:3) Caiaphas: Joseph Caiaphas, high priest AD 18–36, son-in-law of Annas (John 18:13). His ossuary may have been found in Jerusalem in 1990.
- c (26:6) The leper: presumably a man Jesus had healed, since lepers were barred from ordinary contact.
- d (26:7) Alabaster jar: a flask of translucent stone with a long neck that was broken to pour out the contents.
- e (26:9) A high price: Mark 14:5 says "more than three hundred denarii," about a year's wages.
- f (26:11) Deut 15:11.
- g (26:15) Thirty silver coins: literally "thirty pieces of silver," probably shekels or Tyrian tetradrachms, about four months' wages. Compare Zech 11:12, and Exod 21:32, where thirty shekels is the compensation for a slave gored to death.

- h (26:17) Unleavened Bread: the seven-day festival following Passover, during which no leavened bread was eaten (Exod 12:15–20). The two were often named together.
- i (26:20) The Twelve: the Westcott–Hort text prints “disciples” after “the Twelve” in brackets, as uncertain.
- j (26:25) You have said it: an affirmative answer, though guarded: “It is as you say,” or “Those are your words.” Also in verse 64 and 27:11.
- k (26:28) My blood of the covenant: compare Exod 24:8; Jer 31:31–34; Zech 9:11. Many manuscripts read “the new covenant,” as in Luke 22:20 and 1 Cor 11:25; the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts, lacks “new.”
- l (26:30) The hymn: probably the second part of the Hallel (Pss 113–118), sung at the end of the Passover meal.
- m (26:31) Zech 13:7, where Yahweh is the speaker.
- n (26:36) Gethsemane: from Hebrew or Aramaic *gat shemanim*, “oil press,” an olive grove at the foot of the Mount of Olives.
- o (26:38) Compare Ps 42:5, 11; 43:5; Jonah 4:9.
- p (26:45) Are you still sleeping and resting? Or, as a command, “Sleep on now, and take your rest.”
- q (26:50) Do what you are here to do: or, as a question, “Friend, what are you here for?” The Greek is elliptical.
- r (26:53) Legions: a Roman legion had about 6,000 soldiers; twelve legions would be some 72,000.
- s (26:59) Sanhedrin: the supreme Jewish council in Jerusalem, of about seventy-one members, chaired by the high priest.
- t (26:64) The Power: a reverent way of referring to God without saying the name.
- u (26:64) Ps 110:1; Dan 7:13.
- v (26:65) Ripped his clothes: a sign of grief or horror, required of judges on hearing blasphemy.
- w (26:73) The way you talk gives you away: Galileans had a distinctive accent.

Chapter 27

1 When morning came, all the chief priests and the elders of the
people took counsel together against Jesus, to bring about his death.
2 They put him in chains, took him off, and delivered him to Pilate,
the Roman governor.[a]
3 Then Judas, his betrayer, seeing that Jesus had been condemned, was
seized with remorse and brought the thirty silver coins back to the
chief priests and the elders. 4 “I have sinned,” he said, “in betraying
innocent blood.” But they said, “What is that to us? See to it yourself.”
5 Flinging the silver into the sanctuary, he left, and he went off and

hanged himself.[b] 6 The chief priests gathered up the coins. "We may
not lawfully put these in the temple treasury," they said, "because it
is blood money." 7 After discussing the matter, they bought with it
the potter's field, to bury strangers in. 8 That is why that field has
been called the Field of Blood[c] to this day. 9 Then the words spoken
through the prophet Jeremiah came true: "They took the thirty pieces
of silver, the price of the one who was priced by the people of Israel,
10 and they gave them for the potter's field, as the Lord directed me."[d]
11 Jesus now stood before the governor, and the governor questioned
him: "Are you the King of the Jews?" Jesus said, "You say so." 12 But
when the chief priests and elders brought their accusations against
him, he made no answer. 13 Then Pilate said to him, "Do you not hear
how many charges they are bringing against you?" 14 But he did not
answer him with so much as a single word, so that the governor was
greatly amazed.
15 At the festival the governor customarily set free one prisoner for
the crowd, whichever one they wanted. 16 They had in custody just
then a prisoner of some notoriety, Barabbas[e] by name. 17 So when the
people had gathered, Pilate asked them, "Whom do you want me to
release for you, Barabbas, or Jesus who is called Messiah?" 18 For he
knew it was out of envy that they had handed Jesus over. 19 While he
was sitting on the judgment seat, his wife sent word to him: "Have
nothing to do with that righteous man, for today I have suffered
greatly in a dream because of him." 20 But the chief priests and the
elders persuaded the crowds to ask for Barabbas and to have Jesus put
to death. 21 The governor spoke to them again: "Which of the two do
you want me to release for you?" And they said, "Barabbas." 22 "What,
then, am I to do with Jesus, the so-called Messiah?" Pilate asked them.
"Crucify him!" they all replied. 23 "Why," he said, "what wrong has
he committed?" But they only shouted the louder, "Crucify him!" 24
When Pilate saw that he was accomplishing nothing, but that a riot
was starting instead, he took water and washed his hands before the
crowd,[f] saying, "I am innocent of this blood.[g] See to it yourselves."
25 And all the people answered, "His blood be on us and on our chil-

dren!” 26 So he set Barabbas free for them, and he had Jesus scourged[h]
and handed over for crucifixion.
27 Then the governor’s soldiers took Jesus into the governor’s head-
quarters[i] and gathered the whole cohort[j] around him. 28 They stripped
him and put a scarlet military cloak on him, 29 They wove a crown
of thorns and placed it on his head, and a reed in his right hand.
Then they knelt down before him and ridiculed him: “Hail, King of
the Jews!” 30 They spat on him, took the reed, and kept striking him
on the head. 31 When they had finished mocking him, they stripped
him of the cloak, put his own clothes on him, and led him away to
crucify him.
32 On their way out they met a Cyrenian[k] called Simon, and they
pressed him into service to carry Jesus’s cross. 33 They arrived at the
spot named Golgotha, that is, the Skull Place,[l] 34 and offered him wine
mingled with gall[m] to drink; he tasted it but refused to drink. 35 Having
crucified him, they cast lots to share out his garments among them.[n] 36
And they sat there guarding him. 37 Over his head they fixed the notice
of the charge against him: THIS IS JESUS, THE KING OF THE JEWS.
38 Then two bandits were crucified with him, one on the right and one
on the left. 39 The passers-by jeered at him, wagging their heads[o] 40 and
saying, “You who would destroy the sanctuary and build it in three
days, save yourself! If you are the Son of God, come down from the
cross!” 41 In the same way the chief priests, with the scribes and elders,
mocked him and said, 42 “He saved others; himself he cannot save! He
is the King of Israel; let him come down now from the cross, and we
will believe in him. 43 He trusts in God; let God rescue him now, if he
wants him;[p] for he said, ‘I am the Son of God.’ ” 44 Even the bandits
crucified alongside him heaped the same insults on him.
45 From noon until three in the afternoon[q] darkness lay over all the
land. 46 And about three o’clock Jesus cried out with a loud voice, “Eloi,
Eloi, lema sabachthani?” which means, “My God, my God, why have
you forsaken me?”[r] 47 When some of those standing there heard it,
they said, “This man is calling for Elijah.” 48 One of them quickly ran,
got a sponge, soaked it in sour wine,[s] fixed it on a reed, and offered
it to him to drink. 49 But the others said, “Wait, let us see whether

Elijah comes to save him." [[And another took a spear and pierced his side, and out came water and blood.]][t] 50 And Jesus cried out again with a loud voice and gave up his spirit. 51 And look, the curtain of the sanctuary[u] split in two, from the top down to the bottom; the ground quaked and rocks burst apart. 52 The tombs were opened, and many bodies of the saints who had fallen asleep were raised; 53 and coming out of the tombs after his resurrection, they went into the holy city and appeared to many. 54 The centurion and his men who were guarding Jesus, seeing the earthquake and all that was taking place, were overcome with fear and said, "This man really was the Son of God!"[v] 55 Many women were also there, watching from a distance; they had followed Jesus from Galilee and had looked after his needs. 56 Among them were Mary Magdalene,[w] Mary the mother of James and Joseph,[x] and the mother of the sons of Zebedee.

57 When evening had come, a rich man from Arimathea[y] named Joseph arrived, who had himself become a disciple of Jesus. 58 He went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus. Then Pilate ordered it to be given to him. 59 Joseph took the body and wrapped it in a clean linen cloth 60 and placed it in his own new tomb that he had carved out of the rock. Then he rolled a huge stone across the entrance of the tomb and left. 61 Mary Magdalene was there, and the other Mary, sitting across from the grave.

62 The next day, the day after the Preparation,[z] the chief priests and the Pharisees gathered before Pilate 63 and said, "Sir, we remember that while he was still alive that impostor said, 'After three days I will rise again.' 64 So give the order to have the tomb kept secure until the third day. Otherwise his disciples might come and steal him, and then tell the people, 'He has risen from the dead.' That final fraud would be worse than the first." 65 Pilate said to them, "You have a guard.[aa] Go, make it as secure as you know how." 66 So they went and secured the tomb by sealing the stone and setting the guard.

Notes

- a (27:2) Pilate the governor: Pontius Pilate, Roman prefect of Judea AD 26–36. An inscription bearing his name and title was found at Caesarea in 1961.
- b (27:5) Hanged himself: Acts 1:18 gives another account of Judas's death.

- c (27:8) Field of Blood: called in Aramaic *Hakeldama* (Acts 1:19).
- d (27:10) Zech 11:12–13, combined with themes from Jeremiah (Jer 18:1–12; 19:1–13; 32:6–15), which may be why Matthew names Jeremiah. In Zechariah the speaker is Yahweh, here rendered "the Lord." The Greek follows neither the Hebrew nor the Greek Old Testament exactly. Scholarly review recommended.
- e (27:16) Barabbas: Aramaic *Bar-abba*, "son of the father." Some manuscripts, including Θ, family 1 and the Sinaitic Syriac, read "Jesus Barabbas" here and in verse 17, a reading Origen knew and which many scholars consider original; the Westcott–Hort text lacks it. Scholarly review recommended.
- f (27:24) Washed his hands: a Jewish rite declaring innocence of bloodshed (Deut 21:6–9; Ps 26:6).
- g (27:24) This blood: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and Bezae; most manuscripts read "this righteous man's blood."
- h (27:26) Scourged: Roman flogging with a whip of leather thongs weighted with bone or metal, which often preceded crucifixion.
- i (27:27) Headquarters: Greek *praitōrion* (Latin *praetorium*), the governor's official residence in Jerusalem, probably Herod's palace.
- j (27:27) Cohort: a Roman military unit, nominally 600 soldiers, though perhaps fewer were actually present.
- k (27:32) A Cyrenian: a man from Cyrene, a city in North Africa (modern Libya) with a large Jewish community. Mark 15:21 names Simon's sons, Alexander and Rufus.
- l (27:33) Golgotha: from Aramaic *gulgulta*, "skull." The traditional English "Calvary" comes from the Latin *calvaria*, "skull."
- m (27:34) Gall: a bitter substance. Compare Ps 69:21 (69:22 in Hebrew). Many manuscripts read "sour wine" for "wine."
- n (27:35) Ps 22:18 (22:19 in Hebrew). Many later manuscripts add, from John 19:24, "in order that what was spoken by the prophet might be fulfilled: 'They divided my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots.' "
- o (27:39) Shaking their heads: Ps 22:7 (22:8 in Hebrew); compare Lam 2:15.
- p (27:43) Ps 22:8 (22:9 in Hebrew); compare Wis 2:13, 18–20.
- q (27:45) From noon until three in the afternoon: literally "from the sixth hour until the ninth hour." Also verse 46.
- r (27:46) Ps 22:1 (22:2 in Hebrew). *Eloi* is Aramaic for "my God"; *lema sabachthani* is Aramaic, "why have you forsaken me?" The Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, reads *Elōi* here as in Mark 15:34; most manuscripts read the Hebrew form *Eli*, which better explains the bystanders' mistake about Elijah (verse 47).
- s (27:48) Sour wine: Greek *oxos*, cheap sour wine diluted with water, a common drink of soldiers and laborers. Compare Ps 69:21.
- t (27:49) The words in double brackets are found in Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, C, L and some other witnesses, but are absent from most manuscripts, including A, D, W

and Θ, and from the Old Latin and Syriac versions. They resemble John 19:34, where the piercing follows Jesus's death. Westcott and Hort printed them in double brackets as a very early insertion, though they discussed the possibility that they are original. Scholarly review recommended.

- u (27:51) Curtain of the sanctuary: probably the inner curtain that separated the Most Holy Place from the Holy Place (Exod 26:31–33), through which only the high priest passed, once a year.
- v (27:54) God's Son: or "a son of God."
- w (27:56) Mary Magdalene: Mary from Magdala, a town on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee. *Mary* is the Greek form of *Miriam*, perhaps "beloved" or "bitter"; *Magdala* means "tower."
- x (27:56) Joseph: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus (first hand); many manuscripts read *Joses*, as in Mark 15:40.
- y (27:57) Arimathea: probably *Ramathaim*, the hometown of Samuel (1 Sam 1:1), northwest of Jerusalem.
- z (27:62) The Preparation: the day before the Sabbath, that is, Friday, on which preparations for the Sabbath were made.
- aa (27:65) You have a guard: or, as a command, "Take a guard."

Chapter 28

1 When the Sabbath was over, at the dawning of the first day of the
week,[a] Mary Magdalene went with the other Mary to view the grave.
2 And all at once the earth shook violently; for an angel of the Lord
came down from heaven, rolled back the stone, and sat upon it. 3 His
appearance was like lightning, and his clothing white as snow. 4 The
guards shook with fear of him and became like dead men. 5 But the
angel spoke to the women: "As for you, have no fear. I know that you
are looking for Jesus, the one who was crucified. 6 He is not here; he
has been raised, just as he said. Come and see the place where he lay.[b]
7 Now go quickly and tell his disciples, 'He has been raised from the
dead, and he is going to Galilee ahead of you; you will see him there.'
This is what I have told you." 8 They hurried away from the tomb,
frightened yet overjoyed, and ran to bring the news to his disciples. 9
And suddenly Jesus met them and said, "Greetings!"[c] They came up,
clasped his feet, and worshiped him. 10 Then Jesus said to them, "Have
no fear. Go and tell my brothers to set out for Galilee; they will see
me there."

11 As the women went on their way, some members of the guard
came into the city and told the chief priests all that had occurred. 12
The chief priests met with the elders and, after deliberating, gave the
soldiers a large sum of money, 13 and instructing them, "Tell people,
'His disciples came in the night and stole him away while we slept.' 14
And if the governor hears about this, we will persuade him and keep
you out of trouble." 15 So they took the money and did as they had
been instructed. And this story has been spread around among the
Jews to the present day.
16 The eleven disciples went to Galilee, to the mountain where Jesus
had directed them to go. 17 When they saw him, they worshiped him;
but some had doubts.[d] 18 Jesus came near and spoke to them: "All au-
thority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.[e] 19 Go, therefore,
and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in[f] the name of
the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, 20 and teaching them
to keep everything I have commanded you. And remember, I am with
you every day, until the end of the age."[g]

Notes

- a (28:1) At the dawning of the first day of the week: Sunday morning. The Greek may also mean "late on the Sabbath, as the first day of the week was drawing on," that is, Saturday evening, since the Jewish day began at sunset.
- b (28:6) Where he lay: many manuscripts read "where the Lord lay"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks "the Lord."
- c (28:9) Greetings: Greek *chairete*, literally "rejoice," the ordinary greeting.
- d (28:17) But some had doubts: or "but they hesitated."
- e (28:18) Compare Dan 7:14.
- f (28:19) In: Greek *eis*, "into," expressing entry into a relationship with the one named.
- g (28:20) Many manuscripts add a final "Amen"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and others, lacks it.

Mark

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Here begins the good news[a] of Jesus the Messiah[b] [God's Son].[c]
2 It is written in the prophet Isaiah:[d]
"See, ahead of you I send my envoy,
who will prepare your path.
3 A voice of someone shouting in the wilderness:
'Make ready the way of the Lord;
straighten out the paths he will take.' "
4 And so John the Baptizer[e] came on the scene in the wilderness, calling people to be baptized as a sign of repentance,[f] for the forgiveness of their sins.
5 The whole Judean countryside and all the people of Jerusalem kept streaming out to him, and as they confessed their sins they were baptized by him in the Jordan River.
6 John wore a garment of camel's hair, with a leather belt about his waist, and he lived on locusts and wild honey.
7 He proclaimed, "One stronger than I is coming after me. I am not worthy even to bend low and loosen the thong of his sandals.
8 I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit."
9 It was in those days that Jesus came from Nazareth[g] in Galilee[h] and was baptized by John in the Jordan. 10 The moment he came up out of the water, he saw the heavens being torn apart and the Spirit coming down upon him like a dove. 11 And a voice sounded from the heavens: "You are my Son, the one I love; in you I take delight."[i]
12 Straightaway the Spirit drove him out into the wilderness. 13 For forty days he remained in the desert while Satan tested him.[j] He lived among wild beasts, and angels looked after him.

14 After John had been handed over,[k] Jesus went into Galilee announcing the good news of God. 15 "The appointed time has arrived," he said,
"and God's kingdom has drawn near. Turn your lives around, and put
your trust in the good news."
16 Walking beside the Sea of Galilee, he spotted Simon[l] together with
Simon's brother Andrew[m], who were casting a net into the water;
fishing was their trade. 17 Jesus said to them, "Come, follow me, and I
will make you into fishers of people." 18 They dropped their nets on the
spot and went after him. 19 A little further on he noticed James[n] son of
Zebedee[o] and James's brother John in their boat, repairing their nets.
20 Right away he called them. They abandoned their father Zebedee
in the boat with his employees and followed Jesus.
21 Then they entered Capernaum.[p] When the Sabbath arrived, Jesus
walked into the synagogue and started to teach. 22 The people were
astonished at his teaching, because he taught them as someone with
authority of his own, and not in the manner of the scribes.[q] 23 Just then,
in their synagogue, there was a man in the grip of an unclean spirit,
and he shrieked, 24 "Jesus the Nazarene, what have you to do with us?
Have you come to wipe us out? I know exactly who you are: God's
Holy One!" 25 Jesus rebuked it: "Be silent, and come out of him!" 26 The
unclean spirit threw the man into convulsions, gave a loud cry, and
came out of him. 27 All of them were astonished and kept asking one
another, "What does this mean? This is a fresh teaching, delivered
with authority! He commands even unclean spirits, and they do as he
says!" 28 And the report about him spread swiftly in every direction,
through the whole region surrounding Galilee.
29 As soon as they left the synagogue, they entered the home of
Simon and Andrew, accompanied by James and John. 30 Simon's wife's
mother was lying down, burning with fever, and right away they told
Jesus about her. 31 He went to her, took her by the hand, and raised
her up. The fever left her, and she began to serve them.
32 At evening, once the sun had set, they brought to him everyone
who was sick or demon-possessed. 33 The entire town gathered at
the door. 34 He cured many people troubled by various illnesses and

expelled many demons. He refused to let the demons speak, because they recognized him.[r]

35 Very early, while it was still quite dark, Jesus got up, went out to a deserted place, and prayed there. 36 Simon and his companions went searching for him, 37 When they located him, they told him, "Everyone is searching for you." 38 He replied, "Let us move on to the neighboring market towns, so that I may proclaim the message there as well. That is what I came out to do." 39 So he went throughout Galilee, preaching in their synagogues and casting out demons.

40 A man with a skin disease[s] came up to him, dropped to his knees, and pleaded, "If you choose, you have the power to make me clean." 41 Jesus, his heart going out to the man,[t] stretched out his hand and touched him, saying, "I want to. Be cleansed." 42 The disease left him that instant, and he was cleansed. 43 Jesus sent him off at once with a stern warning:[u] 44 "See that you tell no one anything. Rather, go and let the priest examine you, and present for your cleansing the gift that Moses commanded, as a testimony to them."[v] 45 But the man went out and started talking freely, spreading the story far and wide, so that Jesus could no longer enter a town openly. He stayed out in lonely places, and still people came to him from everywhere.

Notes

- a (1:1) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally "gospel."
- b (1:1) Christ: Greek *Christos*, "anointed one," translating Hebrew *mashiach* ("Messiah"). *Jesus* is the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (*Yehoshua*, Joshua), "Yahweh saves."
- c (1:1) [The Son of God]: the words are bracketed because the manuscripts are divided. They stand in Vaticanus, Bezae and most later manuscripts, but are absent from the first hand of Sinaiticus, from Koridethi (Θ), and from several early writers (Origen). The Westcott–Hort text places them in the margin; Tischendorf omits them; the Nestle–Aland and SBL editions print or bracket them differently. Accidental omission by a scribe (the title is abbreviated in manuscripts) and later addition are both possible.
- d (1:2) Mal 3:1 combined with Exod 23:20, and then (verse 3) Isa 40:3 in the wording of the Greek Old Testament; Mark names Isaiah, the more prominent prophet. In Isa 40:3 Hebrew, "the Lord" is Yahweh. Many later manuscripts read "in the prophets."
- e (1:4) John the Baptizer: literally "John the one who baptizes." *John* is Greek for Hebrew *Yohanan*, "Yahweh has been gracious."

- f (1:4) Repentance: Greek *metanoia*, a change of mind and direction of life; in verse 15 the verb is rendered “turn your lives around.” *As a sign of repentance*: literally “a baptism of repentance.”
- g (1:9) Nazareth: a village in lower Galilee, perhaps from Hebrew *netser*, “branch” or “shoot.”
- h (1:9) Galilee: from Hebrew *galil*, “circle” or “district.”
- i (1:11) Ps 2:7; Isa 42:1; compare Gen 22:2. *The one I love*: or “my beloved Son.”
- j (1:13) Satan: Hebrew for “adversary,” “accuser.”
- k (1:14) Handed over: that is, arrested and imprisoned (6:17).
- l (1:16) Simon: a Greek name close to Hebrew *Shimon*, “he has heard.” He is later named Peter (3:16).
- m (1:16) Andrew: a Greek name meaning “manly.”
- n (1:19) James: Greek *Iakōbos*, the Hebrew name *Yaakov* (Jacob), “he grasps the heel” (Gen 25:26).
- o (1:19) Zebedee: from Hebrew *Zebadiah*, “Yahweh has given.”
- p (1:21) Capernaum: from Hebrew *Kefar Nahum*, “village of Nahum,” on the northwest shore of the lake.
- q (1:22) Scribes: experts in the Law of Moses and its interpretation.
- r (1:34) Who he was: Vaticanus and some other manuscripts add “to be the Christ”; the Westcott–Hort text brackets the words in its margin.
- s (1:40) Skin disease: Greek *lepros*, traditionally “leper,” covering a range of skin diseases that made a person ritually unclean (Lev 13–14). *Falling on his knees* is bracketed by Westcott–Hort as doubtful.
- t (1:41) His heart going out to the man: Greek *splanchnistheis*, the reading of Westcott–Hort and nearly all manuscripts. Codex Bezae (D) and a few Old Latin manuscripts read *orgistheis*, “becoming angry.” Some scholars and modern translations prefer “angry” as the harder reading that scribes would have softened; compare the strong verb in verse 43 and 3:5. This is noted for scholarly review.
- u (1:43) With a stern warning: Greek *embrimēsamenos*, a word expressing strong feeling, “snorting” or “speaking harshly.”
- v (1:44) Lev 14:1–32. *As evidence for them*: or “as a testimony against them.”

Chapter 2

1 Some days later, when Jesus came back to Capernaum, word went around that he was at home. 2 So many people crowded in that there was no space left, not even outside the door, and he was speaking the message to them. 3 A group came along with a man who could not move, borne along by four bearers. 4 Since the crowd kept them from getting him near Jesus, they stripped away the roof above the spot where he was, and when they had dug through it, they let down the

mat the paralyzed man was lying on.[a] 5 When Jesus saw how they
trusted, he spoke to the man: “Son, your sins have been forgiven you.”
6 Now some of the scribes were sitting there, turning this over in their
minds: 7 “Why does this fellow talk like that? It is blasphemy! Who
can forgive sins except God alone?” 8 Jesus immediately sensed in his
spirit what was going on in their thoughts, and he asked them, “Why
are you debating these matters inwardly? 9 Which is easier—to tell
the paralyzed man, ‘Your sins are forgiven,’ or to tell him, ‘Get up,
pick up your mat, and walk’? 10 But so that you may know that the
Son of Man[b] has authority on earth to forgive sins”—he turned to the
paralyzed man— 11 “To you I say: rise, take your mat, and go back
to your own house.” 12 And the man rose, picked up the mat without
delay, and went out in front of everyone. They were all astounded
and praised God. “Never have we seen such a thing,” they said.
13 Jesus went out again beside the lake. The whole crowd kept coming
to him, and he taught them. 14 As he walked along, he noticed Levi[c]
the son of Alphaeus[d] sitting at the tax booth. “Follow me,” he told
him. And Levi rose and followed him.
15 Afterward, as Jesus sat at dinner in Levi’s home,[e] many tax collec-
tors[f] and sinners shared the meal with him and his disciples; indeed,
a great number of them were following him. 16 When the scribes
who belonged to the Pharisees[g] saw him eating with sinners and tax
collectors, they asked his disciples, “He eats with tax collectors and
sinners?”[h] 17 Jesus heard it and told them, “It is not people in good
health who need a doctor, but those who are ill. I did not come to call
the righteous; I came to call sinners.”
18 John’s disciples and the Pharisees were fasting. Some people
approached Jesus and asked, “Why do the disciples of John and of
the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not?” 19 Jesus replied, “Can
the groom’s guests[i] fast while the groom is with them? For as long
as the groom is in their midst, they cannot fast. 20 The time will come,
though, when the groom is taken away from them. On that day they
will fast.
21 “No one sews a piece of new, unshrunk fabric onto an old garment.
Otherwise the new piece tugs away from the old, and the rip becomes

worse. 22 Nor does anybody pour new wine into old wineskins. If he
does, the wine will burst the skins, and both the wine and the skins
are lost. New wine calls for fresh skins."[j]
23 It happened that on a Sabbath he was going through fields of
standing grain, and his disciples, while walking, started to pick the
ears. 24 The Pharisees said to him, "Look at that! Why are they doing
what is forbidden on the Sabbath?" 25 He answered, "Have you never
read what David[k] did when he was in need and he and his men were
hungry— 26 He entered God's house in the time of Abiathar[l] the high
priest and ate the loaves set before God,[m] which no one but the priests
may eat, and gave some to those with him." 27 Then he said to them,
"The Sabbath was made for the sake of human beings, not human
beings for the sake of the Sabbath. 28 So the Son of Man holds authority
over the Sabbath too."

Notes

- a (2:4) Mat: Greek *krabattos*, a poor person's pallet or camp bed. Palestinian houses usually had flat roofs of beams covered with branches and packed clay, reached by an outside stair.
- b (2:10) Son of Man: Jesus' usual way of referring to himself, from Aramaic *bar enash*, "a human being," and recalling the heavenly figure "like a son of man" in Dan 7:13–14.
- c (2:14) Levi: Hebrew, "joined" or "attached" (Gen 29:34). In Matthew's parallel (Matt 9:9) the tax collector is named Matthew. Codex Bezae and some other manuscripts here read "James the son of Alphaeus" (compare 3:18).
- d (2:14) Alphaeus: perhaps from Aramaic *Halfai*, meaning uncertain, possibly "changing."
- e (2:15) In Levi's house: literally "in his house," which could also mean Jesus' house.
- f (2:15) Tax collectors: local agents who collected tolls and customs for the ruling authorities; they were widely despised as collaborators and cheats.
- g (2:16) Pharisees: probably "separated ones," a lay movement devoted to strict keeping of the Law and its traditions. *The scribes who belonged to the Pharisees* is the Westcott–Hort reading; many manuscripts read "the scribes and the Pharisees."
- h (2:16) He eats with tax collectors and sinners?: or "He eats with tax collectors and sinners!" Many manuscripts add "and drinks."
- i (2:19) Wedding guests: literally "sons of the bridal chamber," the bridegroom's friends.
- j (2:22) The last sentence is bracketed by Westcott–Hort as doubtful; Codex Bezae and some Old Latin manuscripts omit it.

- k (2:25) David: Hebrew, probably “beloved.” See 1 Sam 21:1–6.
- l (2:26) Abiathar: Hebrew, “the father is abundant” or “father of abundance.” In 1 Sam 21 the priest at Nob was Ahimelech, the father of Abiathar; *when Abiathar was high priest* may mean “in the passage about Abiathar” or refer to the better-known priest of that period. Some manuscripts omit the phrase.
- m (2:26) Bread of the Presence: twelve loaves set out each Sabbath before God in the sanctuary (Lev 24:5–9), literally “bread of setting forth.”

Chapter 3

1 Once again he entered the synagogue, and a man with a shriveled
hand happened to be there. 2 People were watching Jesus closely, to
find out if he would heal the man on the Sabbath, in order to have
grounds for accusing him. 3 Jesus told the man whose hand was
shriveled, “Stand up here where everyone can see you.” 4 Then he
asked them, “On the Sabbath, is it lawful to do good or to do harm,
to save a life or to kill?” But they said nothing. 5 Looking around at
them with anger, and grieved by their stubborn hearts, he told the
man, “Stretch out your hand.” He stretched it out, and it was restored.
6 The Pharisees walked out and immediately began plotting with the
Herodians[a] against Jesus, how they might do away with him.
7 Jesus retreated toward the sea with his disciples, and a great crowd
from Galilee went after him. Many also came from Judea, 8 Jerusalem,[b]
Idumea,[c] the territory across the Jordan, and the vicinity of Tyre and
Sidon.[d] A huge crowd arrived, because they had heard what he was
doing. 9 He told his disciples to keep a small boat ready for him
because of the crowd, so that they would not crush him. 10 He had
cured so many that everyone suffering from diseases[e] kept pressing
in on him to touch him. 11 Whenever the unclean spirits caught sight
of him, they would throw themselves down before him and scream,
“You are the Son of God!” 12 But he gave them strict orders not to make
him known.
13 He climbed the mountain and called to himself those he chose, and
they went to him. 14 He chose twelve men—he called them apostles as
well[f]—so that they would stay in his company and so that he could
send them out with the message, 15 and to have authority to cast
out demons. 16 The Twelve he chose[g] were these: Simon, whom he

named Peter;[h] 17 James son of Zebedee, and John the brother of James
(he gave them the name Boanerges, meaning "Sons of Thunder");[i] 18
Andrew, Philip,[j] Bartholomew,[k] Matthew,[l] Thomas,[m] James the son of
Alphaeus, Thaddaeus,[n] Simon the Cananaean,[o] 19 and Judas Iscariot,[p]
who handed him over.
20 He went into a house, and again a crowd gathered, so large that
he and his followers were unable to eat. 21 His relatives[q] heard of this
and went out to seize him, because people were saying, "He has lost
his senses."
22 The scribes who had come from Jerusalem were claiming, "Beelze-
bul[r] has hold of him," and, "He expels demons by the power of the
demons' chief." 23 So he called them over and spoke to them in para-
bles: "How can Satan drive out Satan? 24 If a kingdom is split against
itself, that kingdom cannot last. 25 And if a household is split against
itself, that household will not be able to last. 26 So if Satan has risen
up against himself and is split, he cannot last; his end has come. 27 In
fact, nobody can break into a strong man's house and carry off his
belongings unless he first ties up the strong man; only then can he
loot his house.
28 "Amen, I tell you:[s] the children of humankind will be forgiven all
their sins, and whatever blasphemies they may utter; 29 but whoever
blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness; that person
is guilty of a sin that lasts forever."[t] 30 This was his answer to their
claim that he had an unclean spirit in him.
31 Then his mother and his brothers arrived. They stood outside and
sent word in to him, calling for him. 32 A crowd sat around him. They
said to him, "Your mother and your brothers[u] are outside asking for
you." 33 He answered, "Who are my mother and my brothers?" 34 Then,
looking at the people sitting all around him, he said, "See—my mother
and my brothers are here! 35 Whoever carries out the will of God, that
one is my brother, my sister, my mother."

Notes

- a (3:6) Herodians: supporters of the dynasty of Herod, whose son Herod Antipas then ruled Galilee.

- b (3:8) Jerusalem: in Hebrew *Yerushalayim*, often explained as “foundation of peace.”
- c (3:8) Idumea: the Greek form of Edom (“red”), the region south of Judea.
- d (3:8) Tyre and Sidon: Phoenician coastal cities north of Galilee. *Tyre* means “rock”; *Sidon* probably “fishing place.”
- e (3:10) Afflictions: literally “scourges,” “torments.”
- f (3:14) He called them apostles as well: the phrase stands in the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, but is lacking in many manuscripts and may have come in from Luke 6:13. *Apostle* means “one sent out.”
- g (3:16) The Twelve he chose: the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, has these words; many manuscripts lack them.
- h (3:16) Peter: Greek *Petros*, “rock” or “stone,” corresponding to Aramaic *Kepha* (Cephas).
- i (3:17) Boanerges: a Greek transliteration, probably of Aramaic *bene regesh* or *bene regaz*, “sons of commotion” or “sons of anger,” which Mark translates “Sons of Thunder.” The exact Aramaic form is uncertain.
- j (3:18) Philip: Greek, “lover of horses.”
- k (3:18) Bartholomew: Aramaic *bar Talmai*, “son of Talmai” (perhaps “furrowed”).
- l (3:18) Matthew: probably from Hebrew *Mattityahu*, “gift of Yahweh.”
- m (3:18) Thomas: Aramaic *Toma*, “twin” (compare John 11:16).
- n (3:18) Thaddaeus: meaning uncertain, perhaps “breast” or “heart,” suggesting “beloved.” In Luke 6:16 the corresponding name is Judas the son of James.
- o (3:18) Cananaean: from Aramaic *qan’ana*, “zealous one,” “zealot” (compare Luke 6:15), not a reference to Canaan or Cana.
- p (3:19) Iscariot: possibly “man of Kerioth,” a town in Judea; other explanations have been proposed. *Judas* is the Greek form of *Judah*, “praised.”
- q (3:21) His family: literally “those from beside him,” that is, his relatives (compare 3:31).
- r (3:22) Beelzebul: a name for the prince of demons, perhaps “lord of the dwelling” or a mocking form of Baal-zebub, “lord of flies” (2 Kgs 1:2).
- s (3:28) Amen, I tell you: Hebrew *amen*, “surely,” “truly,” used by Jesus to begin a solemn statement.
- t (3:29) A sin that lasts forever: literally “an eternal sin”; many later manuscripts read “eternal judgment.”
- u (3:32) Your mother and your brothers: many manuscripts add “and your sisters”; the Westcott–Hort text lacks the words.

Chapter 4

1 Again he started teaching by the sea. The crowd that gathered around him was so enormous that he climbed into a boat and sat there on the water, while all the people lined the shore. 2 He taught

them many things by means of parables,[a] and in the course of his
teaching he said to them: 3 "Listen! A farmer went out to sow seed. 4
As he scattered it, some fell beside the path, and birds came and ate it
up. 5 Other seed fell on rocky places where there was not much soil,
and it shot up quickly because the earth was shallow. 6 But when the
sun rose it was scorched, and having no root, it dried up. 7 Other seed
fell among thornbushes, and the thorns grew up and choked it, and it
yielded no grain. 8 Still other seeds fell into good soil, and they came
up, grew, and produced grain, yielding thirty, sixty, even a hundred
times as much." 9 And he said, "Whoever has ears for hearing, let that
person hear!"
10 When he was by himself, the people around him, together with the
Twelve, asked him about the parables.
11 He told them, "To you the secret[b] of God's kingdom has been given;
but for those outside, everything comes in parables,
12 so that

'looking, they may look but never see,
and listening, they may listen but never grasp,
lest they turn around and be pardoned.' "[c]

13 Then he said to them, "You do not grasp this parable? Then how
will you grasp any of the parables? 14 The sower sows the word. 15 The
ones beside the path are those where the word is sown, but as soon
as they hear it, Satan comes and snatches away the word that was
sown in them. 16 In the same way, the ones sown on rocky ground
are those who, on hearing the word, accept it at once with joy. 17
They have no roots, so they endure only briefly. When hardship or
harassment comes because of the message, they promptly stumble.[d]
18 Others are the ones sown among the thorns: they hear the word, 19
but the worries of this present age, the lure of riches, and cravings for
other things creep in and smother the word, so that it bears nothing.
20 And the ones sown on the good soil are those who hear the word,
welcome it, and bear fruit—thirtyfold, sixtyfold, a hundredfold."
21 He also told them, "Does anyone bring a lamp inside in order to
cover it with a bowl[e] or slide it under a bed? Is it not meant to stand
on a lamp stand? 22 For nothing is concealed except to be brought into

the open, and nothing has been kept secret except to come to light. 23
If anyone has ears for hearing, let that person hear." 24 He continued,
"Take care what you listen to. The standard you apply will be applied
to you, and you will receive even more. 25 To anyone who has, more
will be given; but from anyone who has nothing, even that will be
taken away."
26 He also said, "God's kingdom is like this: a man scatters seed on
the ground; 27 and whether he sleeps or rises, night and day, the seed
sprouts and grows, though he has no idea how. 28 The earth produces
crops by itself—first the shoot, then the head, then the full grain in
the head. 29 And as soon as the crop allows, he sends in the sickle at
once, because harvest time has arrived."[f]
30 He said further, "What can we compare God's kingdom to, or what
parable shall we use for it? 31 It is like a mustard seed. When it is sown
in the ground, it is the tiniest of all the seeds on earth; 32 yet once
sown, it springs up and becomes greater than all the garden plants,
and puts out such large branches that the birds of the sky can find
shelter in its shade."[g]
33 With many such parables he spoke the word to them, as much
as they were able to take in. 34 He did not speak to them without a
parable, yet privately he explained everything to his own disciples.
35 On that same day, in the evening, he told them, "Let's go over to the
opposite shore." 36 So they left the crowd and took him with them in
the boat, since he was already in it; and there were other boats along
with him. 37 A violent windstorm arose, and waves broke over the
boat, until it was nearly swamped. 38 But he was in the stern, asleep
on the cushion. They woke him and said to him, "Teacher, does it not
matter to you that we are about to die?" 39 He got up, rebuked the
wind, and said to the lake, "Hush! Be still!" The wind dropped, and
there was a great calm. 40 He said to them, "Why are you so fearful?
Have you still no faith?"[h] 41 They were overcome with awe and said to
each other, "Who can this be? Even the wind and the lake obey him!"

Notes

- a (4:2) Parables: Greek *parabolē*, a comparison or story that sets one thing beside another to illustrate a truth, sometimes a riddle (Hebrew *mashal*).

- b (4:11) Secret: Greek *mystērion*, “mystery,” a hidden purpose of God now revealed.
- c (4:12) Isa 6:9–10, quoted freely and in a form close to the Aramaic Targum (“be forgiven” for the Hebrew “be healed”).
- d (4:17) Fall away: or “stumble,” “are caused to sin” (Greek *skandalizontai*).
- e (4:21) Basket: Greek *modios*, a grain measure holding about 8.75 liters (about 2 US gallons, a quarter bushel), here the container itself.
- f (4:29) Joel 3:13 (4:13 in Hebrew).
- g (4:32) Compare Ezek 17:23; 31:6; Dan 4:12, 21.
- h (4:40) Have you still no faith?: many manuscripts read “How is it that you have no faith?”

Chapter 5

1 They came to the far side of the lake, into the territory of the
Gerasenes.[a] 2 When he had come ashore from the boat, a man pos-
sessed by an unclean spirit met him, coming from the tombs. 3 He
lived among the tombs, and by this time nobody was able to hold him
down, not even with a chain. 4 Time and again he had been bound
with shackles and chains, but he had snapped the chains apart and
smashed the shackles, and nobody had the strength to subdue him. 5
Night and day, among the tombs and on the hillsides, he kept howling
and gashing himself with stones. 6 Catching sight of Jesus from far
off, he ran and fell down before him, 7 and shouting with a loud cry
he said, “Jesus, Son of God Most High, what is there between you
and me? In God’s name I beg you, do not torture me!” 8 For Jesus
had been saying to him, “Come out of the man, you unclean spirit!” 9
Then Jesus asked him, “What is your name?” He replied, “I am called
Legion,[b] because we are many.” 10 And he begged Jesus over and over
not to send them out of that region. 11 A big herd of swine happened
to be grazing nearby on the slope of the hill. 12 The spirits pleaded
with him, “Send us to the swine, so that we may go into them.” 13 He
gave them leave, and the unclean spirits came out and went into the
swine. The herd, about two thousand of them, rushed down the steep
slope into the lake and were drowned in the water.
14 Those who tended the swine fled and spread the news in the
town and around the farms, and people came out to see what had
happened. 15 They came to Jesus and saw the man who had been pos-

sessed—the one who had held the legion—sitting there clothed and in
his right mind, and they were afraid. 16 Those who had witnessed it
told them what had happened to the demon-possessed man and about
the swine. 17 Then they began urging Jesus to leave their district. 18
While Jesus was boarding the boat, the man freed from the demons
kept begging to be allowed to stay with him. 19 Jesus did not allow
this. Instead he said, "Return to your family and tell them all that the
Lord[c] did for you and how he took pity on you." 20 So the man went
off and began to make known throughout the Decapolis[d] what Jesus
had done for him, and everyone was amazed.
21 Jesus crossed over by boat again to the opposite shore, and a great
crowd came together around him while he was beside the lake. 22
One of the leaders of the synagogue, named Jairus,[e] came along, and
on seeing Jesus, threw himself at his feet 23 and pleaded with him
earnestly: "My little daughter is at death's door. Please come and lay
your hands on her, so that she may get well and live." 24 So Jesus set
off with him. A large crowd followed and pressed in on him from
every side.
25 Among them was a woman who had suffered from bleeding for
twelve years. 26 She had endured a great deal at the hands of many
doctors and had spent everything she owned, yet instead of improv-
ing she had grown worse. 27 She had heard the reports about Jesus,
and she came up behind him in the crowd and touched his cloak, 28 for
she kept telling herself, "If I touch even his clothes, I shall be made
well." 29 At once the flow of her blood dried up, and she sensed in her
body that she was cured of her affliction. 30 Jesus, aware at once that
power had gone out from him, turned around in the crowd and said,
"Who touched my clothes?" 31 His disciples answered, "You see the
crowd jostling you, and still you ask, 'Who touched me?' " 32 But he
kept looking around to see who had done this. 33 The woman, afraid
and shaking because she knew what had happened to her, came and
threw herself down before him and told him everything. 34 He said to
her, "Daughter, your faith has made you well.[f] Go in peace, free from
your affliction."

35 While he was still speaking, messengers arrived from the synagogue
leader's house with the news: "Your daughter has died. There is no
reason to trouble the Teacher further." 36 But Jesus, overhearing[g] what
they said, told the synagogue leader, "Do not be afraid; just keep be-
lieving." 37 He let no one come along with him except Peter, James, and
James's brother John. 38 When they reached the synagogue leader's
house, Jesus saw an uproar, with people weeping and wailing loudly.
39 Going in, he said to them, "Why this commotion and weeping? The
child is not dead; she is sleeping." 40 They laughed at him. But he sent
them all out, took along the child's father and mother and his own
companions, and went into the place where the child was lying. 41
Taking the child by the hand, he said to her, "Talitha koum,"[h] which
translated means, "Little girl, I say to you, get up." 42 Immediately the
girl stood up and began walking about—she was twelve years old—
and at once they were utterly astounded. 43 He charged them firmly
that nobody must know about it, and said that she should be given
food.

Notes

- a (5:1) Gerasenes: the Westcott–Hort reading, referring to Gerasa (modern Jerash), a city of the Decapolis about 35 miles (55 km) southeast of the lake. Other manuscripts read "Gadarenes" (from Gadara, about 6 miles or 10 km from the lake; compare Matt 8:28) or "Gergesenes" (from Gergesa, a site on the eastern shore).
- b (5:9) Legion: a Latin military term for a Roman army unit of up to about 6,000 soldiers.
- c (5:19) The Lord: here God, though Mark may also intend Jesus (compare verse 20).
- d (5:20) Decapolis: Greek, "Ten Cities," a league of Greek-speaking cities mostly east of the Jordan.
- e (5:22) Jairus: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yair*, "he will give light" or "he enlightens" (Num 32:41).
- f (5:34) Made you well: or "saved you" (Greek *sesōken*); also in verses 23 and 28.
- g (5:36) Overhearing: or "ignoring" (Greek *parakousas*). Many manuscripts read "hearing."
- h (5:41) Talitha koum: Aramaic *talyetha qum*, "little girl (lamb), get up," transliterated in Greek. The Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, has *koum*; many manuscripts have *koumi*, the feminine form of the command.

Chapter 6

1 Leaving that place, Jesus went to his hometown, and his disciples
went along with him.
2 When the Sabbath came, he began teaching in the synagogue, and
many who listened were astounded. “Where did this man get all
this?” they asked. “What is this wisdom that has been granted to him?
And such mighty works done by his hands!
3 Is he not the carpenter,[a] the son of Mary,[b] and the brother of James
and Joses[c] and Judas and Simon? And are his sisters not here among
us?” And they took offense at him.
4 Jesus said to them, “A prophet is not without honor except in his
own hometown, among his own relatives, and in his own household.”
5 He could not do any mighty work there, apart from laying his hands
on a few sick people and healing them.
6 He was amazed at their lack of faith.

¶Then he went around the villages in a circuit, teaching.
7 He summoned the Twelve and began sending them out two by two,
and he gave them authority over the unclean spirits.
8 He instructed them to take nothing for the road but a staff—no bread,
no bag, no small change[d] in their belts—
9 but to wear sandals, and “do not put on two tunics.”
10 He said to them, “Wherever you enter a house, stay there until you
leave that place.
11 And wherever people refuse to welcome you or hear you out, shake
off the dust from under your feet when you go, as a witness to them.”[e]
12 So they set out and proclaimed that people should repent.
13 Many demons were cast out by them, and many who were ill were
anointed with oil by them and cured.
14 Now King Herod[f] came to hear of it, since the name of Jesus was on
everyone’s lips. Some were saying,[g] “This is John the Baptizer risen
from the dead; that explains why such powers are active in him.” 15
Others said, “He is Elijah,”[h] and still others, “He is a prophet, like one
of the prophets of old.” 16 But when Herod heard of it, he said, “John,
the man I beheaded—he has been raised!”

17 Herod himself had given the order to seize John and tie him up
in prison. He did it because of Herodias,[i] the wife of his brother
Philip, whom Herod had married. 18 John had been telling Herod, "It
is not lawful for you to have your brother's wife."[j] 19 So Herodias
held a grudge against him and wanted him killed, but she could not
manage it, 20 because Herod stood in awe of John, knowing him to
be a righteous and holy man, and kept him safe. When he heard
him, he was greatly perplexed;[k] yet he liked to listen to him. 21 But a
suitable day arrived: Herod, celebrating his birthday, held a feast for
his courtiers, the army officers, and the foremost people of Galilee. 22
His daughter Herodias[l] came in and danced, and she delighted Herod
and his guests. The king said to the girl, "Ask me for anything you
like, and I will give it to you." 23 And he swore to her with an oath,
"Whatever you ask me, I will give you, up to half of my kingdom."
24 She went out and asked her mother, "What shall I ask for?" Her
mother answered, "The head of John the Baptizer." 25 The girl hurried
straight back to the king and made her request: "I want you to give
me, here and now, on a platter, the head of John the Baptist." 26 Though
the king was very sorry, he would not turn her down, out of regard
for the oaths he had sworn and for the guests at his table. 27 Without
delay he dispatched a soldier of the guard[m] and ordered him to fetch
John's head. The man went and cut off John's head there in the prison,
28 carried it in on a platter, and handed it to the girl; and she handed it
to her mother. 29 When John's disciples heard about this, they came,
took his body away, and put it in a tomb.
30 The apostles came back together to Jesus and told him everything
—what they had done and what they had taught. 31 "Come with me,
just yourselves, to some out-of-the-way spot, and get a little rest,"
he told them. So many were arriving and departing that they had no
chance even to eat. 32 They left in the boat to go to an isolated spot
by themselves. 33 But many people saw them leaving and recognized
them, and they ran there together on foot from all the towns and
got there before them. 34 As Jesus came ashore, he saw a great crowd
and felt compassion for them, because they were like sheep without
a shepherd;[n] and he began to teach them many things.

35 By the time it was late in the day, his disciples approached him and
said, “This place is remote, and it is already getting late. 36 Dismiss
them, so they can go off to the surrounding farms and villages and
buy food for themselves.” 37 He replied, “Feed them yourselves.” They
asked him, “Shall we go off and buy two hundred days’ wages[o] worth
of bread to give them a meal?” 38 “How many loaves have you got?”
he asked. “Go and look.” They checked and reported, “Five—and two
fish.” 39 Then he told them to have everyone sit down in groups on
the green grass. 40 So they sat down in companies, by hundreds and
by fifties. 41 He took the five loaves and the two fish, looked up to
heaven, spoke the blessing,[p] broke the loaves, and kept handing them
to his disciples to set before the people; and he divided the two fish
among them all. 42 Everyone ate and was satisfied, 43 and they picked
up twelve baskets full of broken pieces of bread and of the fish. 44 The
men who ate the bread came to five thousand.
45 Right away Jesus made his disciples get into the boat and go on
ahead of him to the other side, to Bethsaida,[q] while he sent the crowd
away. 46 After he had taken leave of them, he went up the mountain
to pray. 47 Evening fell. The boat was far out on the lake, and he was
by himself on the shore. 48 He saw that they were straining at the
oars, since the wind was blowing against them. Sometime between
three and six in the morning[r] he went out to them, walking on the
lake, and was going to pass them by.[s] 49 but when they caught sight
of him walking on the water, they supposed he was a phantom and
screamed; 50 for they all saw him and were terrified. But at once he
spoke with them and said, “Take courage! It is I.[t] Do not be afraid.” 51
Then he climbed into the boat with them, and the wind died down.
They were utterly astounded, 52 They had not grasped the meaning of
the loaves; instead, their minds were closed.
53 When they had crossed over, they came to land at Gennesaret[u]
and moored the boat. 54 The moment they stepped ashore, the people
knew who he was. 55 and ran throughout that whole region and
began to carry the sick on their mats to wherever they heard he was.
56 Wherever he went, whether to villages, towns or farms, people
would set the sick down in the marketplaces and plead with him to

let them touch just the tassel[v] of his cloak. Everyone who touched it was healed.

Notes

- a (6:3) Carpenter: Greek *tektōn*, a craftsman who worked in wood or stone, a builder. Many later manuscripts, and P45 as reported, read "the son of the carpenter" (compare Matt 13:55).
- b (6:3) Mary: Greek *Maria* (*Mariam*), from Hebrew *Miryam*, of uncertain meaning; suggestions include "beloved" and "bitter."
- c (6:3) Joses: a Greek form of *Joseph* (Hebrew, "may he add"). Matthew 13:55 has "Joseph."
- d (6:8) Small change: literally "copper (coins)."
- e (6:11) Many manuscripts add "Amen, I tell you, it will be easier for Sodom and Gomorrah on the day of judgment than for that town" (compare Matt 10:15); the Westcott–Hort text lacks it.
- f (6:14) King Herod: Herod Antipas, son of Herod the Great, ruler of Galilee and Perea (4 BC–AD 39). His official title was "tetrarch" (Matt 14:1); Mark uses the popular title "king." *Herod* means "heroic."
- g (6:14) People were saying: the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and some other manuscripts, has the plural; most manuscripts read "he was saying."
- h (6:15) Elijah: Hebrew, "my God is Yahweh." He was expected to return before the day of the Lord (Mal 4:5).
- i (6:17) Herodias: granddaughter of Herod the Great. According to Josephus her first husband was Herod (a son of Herod the Great), whom some identify with Philip; the tetrarch Philip married her daughter Salome.
- j (6:18) Lev 18:16; 20:21.
- k (6:20) He was greatly perplexed: the reading of Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and Westcott–Hort (Greek *ēporei*); most manuscripts read "he did many things" (*epoiei*).
- l (6:22) His daughter Herodias: the reading of Westcott–Hort with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, which makes the girl Herod's own daughter, also named Herodias. Most manuscripts read "the daughter of Herodias herself"; Josephus names her Salome ("peace"). Noted for review.
- m (6:27) A soldier of the guard: Greek *spekoulatōr*, a Latin loanword for a scout or bodyguard, who also served as executioner.
- n (6:34) Num 27:17; 1 Kgs 22:17; Ezek 34:5.
- o (6:37) Two hundred days' wages: Greek "two hundred denarii." A denarius was a silver coin, the usual pay for a day's work by a laborer (Matt 20:2).
- p (6:41) Spoke the blessing: that is, gave thanks to God for the food, according to Jewish custom.
- q (6:45) Bethsaida: Aramaic, "house of fishing," a town at the northern end of the lake.

- r (6:48) Between three and six in the morning: literally “about the fourth watch of the night.” The Romans divided the night from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m. into four watches.
- s (6:48) He meant to pass by them: compare God passing by Moses and Elijah (Exod 33:19–22; 1 Kgs 19:11).
- t (6:50) It is I: Greek *egō eimi*, literally “I am,” which may also echo God’s self-designation (Exod 3:14; Isa 43:10).
- u (6:53) Gennesaret: a fertile plain on the northwest shore of the lake, south of Capernaum; the name may mean “garden of riches” or “harp,” of uncertain derivation.
- v (6:56) Tassel: or “fringe,” “edge”; compare Num 15:38–39.

Chapter 7

1 The Pharisees and some of the scribes who had come from Jerusalem
gathered around Jesus.
2 They saw that some of his disciples were eating with hands that
were unclean, meaning unwashed.
3 (The Pharisees, and indeed all the Jews, do not eat unless they wash
their hands thoroughly,[a] holding fast to the tradition of the elders;
4 and when they come in from the marketplace they do not eat unless
they purify themselves.[b] There are many other customs they have
received and keep, such as the washing of cups, pitchers, and copper
kettles.)[c]
5 So the Pharisees and scribes asked him, “Why do your disciples
not live by the tradition of the elders, but eat their food with defiled
hands?”
6 He answered them, “Isaiah prophesied rightly about you hypocrites,
as it is written:

‘This people honors me with their lips,
but their heart stays far away from me.
7 Their worship of me is empty,
for what they teach as doctrine are human rules.’[d]

8 You abandon God’s commandment and cling to human tradition.”
9 He went on, “How neatly you set aside God’s commandment in order
to keep[e] your own tradition!
10 For Moses said, ‘Honor your father and your mother,’ and, ‘Whoever
curses father or mother must be put to death.’[f]

11 Yet your teaching is that a man may say to his father or his mother,
'Anything of mine that could have helped you is Corban' "—meaning
a gift set apart for God—[g]
12 "and after that you release him from doing anything at all for the
parents who bore him.
13 In this way you make God's word void through the tradition you
pass along. And many other such things you do."
14 He called the crowd over once more and told them, "Everyone, hear
me and understand. 15 Nothing outside a person can make him unclean
by going into him. It is the things that come out of a person that make
him unclean." 16 [h]
17 When he had left the crowd and gone into the house, his disciples
asked him about the parable. 18 He said to them, "Are you also so slow
to understand? Do you not see that nothing that goes into a person
from outside can make him unclean, 19 since it enters not his heart
but his stomach, and passes out into the latrine?" (In saying this,
he declared all foods clean.)[i] 20 He continued, "What comes out of a
person—that is what makes him unclean. 21 For from within, out of the
human heart, come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, 22
adultery, greed, malice, deceit, debauchery, envy,[j] slander, arrogance,
and folly. 23 All these evils come from within, and they make a person
unclean."
24 Jesus rose and left that place for the territory around Tyre [and
Sidon].[k] He went into a house, wishing nobody to find out, but his
presence could not be kept hidden. 25 In fact, a woman whose little
daughter had an unclean spirit heard about him at once, and she came
and fell at his feet. 26 She was a Greek-speaking Gentile,[l] born in Syrian
Phoenicia,[m] and she kept pleading with him to cast the demon out
of her child. 27 He said to her, "Let the children be fed first; it is not
right to take the children's bread and throw it to the little dogs." 28 She
replied, "Lord,[n] that is true, but even the dogs under the table feed
on the scraps the children drop." 29 He said to her, "Because you have
answered this way, you may go; the demon has left your daughter." 30
When she got back to her house, the child was lying on the bed and
the demon had gone out.

31 Then Jesus left the district of Tyre, went through Sidon, and came
to the Sea of Galilee by way of the region of the Decapolis.[o] 32 There
they brought him someone who was deaf and had an impediment in
his speech, and they pleaded with Jesus to place his hand upon him. 33
Taking him away from the crowd to be alone, he placed his fingers in
the man's ears, then spat and touched the man's tongue. 34 Looking up
to heaven, he gave a deep sigh and said to him, "Ephphatha,"[p] which
means, "Be opened." 35 His ears were opened at once, his tongue was
freed, and he spoke clearly. 36 Jesus ordered them to tell no one; but the
more he ordered them, the more widely they proclaimed it. 37 Their
astonishment knew no bounds. "Everything he does is well done,"
they kept saying. "He gives the deaf their hearing and the speechless
their speech."[q]

Notes

- a (7:3) Thoroughly: Greek *pygmē*, literally "with the fist," a phrase of uncertain meaning: perhaps "with a cupped hand," "up to the wrist," or "carefully."
- b (7:4) Purify themselves: literally "sprinkle themselves" (*rhantisōntai*, the reading of Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and Westcott–Hort); most manuscripts read "wash" or "immerse themselves" (*baptisōntai*).
- c (7:4) Copper kettles: many manuscripts add "and dining couches"; the Westcott–Hort text lacks the words.
- d (7:7) Isa 29:13, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- e (7:9) Keep: or "establish" (Greek *stēsēte*, the reading of some manuscripts); the Westcott–Hort text reads *tērēsēte*, "keep."
- f (7:10) Exod 20:12; Deut 5:16; Exod 21:17; Lev 20:9.
- g (7:11) Corban: Hebrew *qorban*, "offering," a gift dedicated to God and so withdrawn from ordinary use; the vow could be used to deny support to one's parents.
- h (7:16) Verse 16 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and other early witnesses. Many later manuscripts add, "If anyone has ears to hear, let that person hear" (compare 4:9, 23).
- i (7:19) He declared all foods clean: literally "cleansing all foods." The words are best taken as Mark's comment. Most later manuscripts read the neuter *katharizon*, which would attach the phrase to the latrine ("which purges all foods").
- j (7:22) Envy: literally "an evil eye."
- k (7:24) Tyre [and Sidon]: the words "and Sidon" are bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; Codex Bezae and some other manuscripts lack them, possibly because they came in from Matt 15:21.
- l (7:26) Greek-speaking Gentile: literally "Greek," meaning a non-Jew.

- m (7:26) Syrian Phoenicia: Greek *Syrophoinikissa*, “Syrophoenician,” from Phoenicia, which belonged to the Roman province of Syria, as distinct from Libyan Phoenicia (Carthage).
- n (7:28) Lord: or “Sir”; Greek *kyrie* was also a polite form of address.
- o (7:31) Many later manuscripts read “Leaving the region of Tyre and Sidon, he came to the Sea of Galilee.”
- p (7:34) Compare Isa 35:5–6.
- q (7:37) Ephphatha: Aramaic, probably *ethpattach* (or *ephattach*), “be opened,” transliterated in Greek.

Chapter 8

1 About that time another vast crowd had collected, and they had
nothing to eat. Jesus called his disciples to him and said, 2 “My heart
goes out to these people. They have been with me for three days
now and have nothing left to eat. 3 If I dismiss them to go home
with empty stomachs, they will collapse along the way, and some of
them have traveled from far away.” 4 His disciples answered, “Where
could anyone get enough bread out here in the wilds to satisfy these
people?” 5 “How many loaves do you have?” he asked. “Seven,” they
said. 6 He told the crowd to sit down on the ground. Then he took the
seven loaves and gave thanks. He broke them and gave them to his
disciples to hand out, and they distributed them to the people. 7 They
also had a few small fish; after blessing them, he told the disciples to
serve these too. 8 The people ate their fill, and they gathered up seven
large baskets[a] of leftover pieces. 9 About four thousand were there.
Then he sent them on their way. 10 Right away he boarded the boat
together with his disciples and came into the parts of Dalmanutha.[b]
11 Out came the Pharisees and began disputing with him, asking him
for a heavenly sign as a way of testing him. 12 Groaning from deep
within, he said, “Why does this generation demand a sign? Truly I
tell you, no sign will be given to this generation.”[c] 13 Leaving them, he
embarked once more and crossed to the opposite shore.
14 Now the disciples had neglected to take any bread along; apart
from a single loaf, they had none in the boat. 15 Jesus warned them,
“Watch out—be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees
and the yeast of Herod.”[d] 16 They kept saying to each other that it
was because they were without bread. 17 Jesus knew what they were

saying and asked, “Why talk about being out of bread? Do you not
yet perceive or comprehend? Have your hearts grown hard? 18 You
have eyes—can you not see? You have ears—can you not hear?[e] And
do you not remember? 19 At the breaking of the five loaves for the
five thousand, how many basketfuls of leftovers did you pick up?”
They replied, “Twelve.” 20 “And at the seven for the four thousand,
how many hampers of leftovers did you fill?” “Seven,” they answered.
21 “Even now you fail to understand?” he said to them.
22 They reached Bethsaida. There some people led a blind man to Jesus
and implored him to lay a hand on him. 23 He took the blind man by
the hand and led him out of the village. When he had spat on his
eyes and laid his hands on him, he asked him, “Do you see anything?”
24 Looking up, the man said, “I can see people—they look to me like
trees moving about.” 25 Then Jesus once more placed his hands on
the man’s eyes. He looked intently, his sight was restored, and he
saw everything clearly. 26 He sent the man back to his house with the
words, “Do not enter the village at all.”[f]
27 Then Jesus went out with his disciples to the villages near Caesarea
Philippi,[g] and as they traveled he put a question to them: “Who do
people say that I am?” 28 They answered him, “John the Baptizer;
others say Elijah; and still others, one of the prophets.” 29 He ques-
tioned them: “And you, who do you say that I am?” Peter replied, “You
are the Messiah.”[h] 30 And he warned them sternly not to tell anyone
about him.
31 Then he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many
things and be rejected by the elders, the chief priests, and the scribes,
and be put to death, and after three days rise again. 32 He was speaking
about this quite openly. Peter took him aside and began to rebuke
him. 33 But Jesus, turning and looking at his disciples, rebuked Peter.
“Get behind me, Satan!”[i] he said. “Your mind is not on God’s concerns
but on human ones.”
34 Summoning the crowd together with his disciples, he told them,
“Anyone who wishes to come after me must renounce self, pick up
their cross, and walk with me. 35 Anyone set on saving his life[j] will
lose it; but if someone loses his life on account of me and the gospel,

that person will keep it safe.[k] 36 What good does it do a person to gain
the whole world and forfeit his life? 37 Indeed, what can a person give
in exchange for his life? 38 For if anyone is embarrassed by me and my
words among this unfaithful and sinful generation, the Son of Man
will be embarrassed by that person when he arrives in his Father's
glory, accompanied by the holy angels."

Notes

- a (8:8) Large baskets: Greek *spyris*, a large woven basket or hamper, distinct from the smaller *kophinos* of 6:43 (compare 8:19–20).
- b (8:10) Dalmanutha: an unknown place, apparently on the western shore of the lake. Some manuscripts read "Magadan" or "Magdala" (compare Matt 15:39).
- c (8:12) No sign will be given: literally "if a sign will be given," a Hebrew form of oath meaning "certainly not."
- d (8:15) Yeast of Herod: P45 (as reported), Koridethi (Θ) and some others read "the yeast of the Herodians."
- e (8:18) Jer 5:21; Ezek 12:2.
- f (8:26) Do not even go into the village: many manuscripts add "or tell anyone in the village."
- g (8:27) Caesarea Philippi: a city near the sources of the Jordan, rebuilt by the tetrarch Philip and named in honor of Caesar Augustus and himself.
- h (8:29) Messiah: Greek *Christos*, "anointed one."
- i (8:33) Satan: Hebrew, "adversary." Peter is acting as an adversary, opposing God's purpose.
- j (8:35) Life: Greek *psychē*, "life," "soul," "self"; so in verses 35–37.
- k (8:35) On account of me and the gospel: the words "me and" are bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; P45 (as reported) and Codex Bezae lack them.

Chapter 9

1 And he said to them, "Amen, I tell you, there are some standing here
who will not taste death until they have seen God's kingdom come
in power."

2 After six days Jesus took along Peter, James, and John, and brought
them up a lofty mountain, privately, with no one else present. There
his appearance was changed[a] in front of them, 3 and his clothes
became dazzling, intensely white, whiter than any bleacher[b] on earth
could make them. 4 Elijah appeared to them together with Moses,[c] and
the two were talking with Jesus. 5 Peter spoke up and said to Jesus,
"Rabbi,[d] how good it is that we are here! Let us put up three shelters—

one for you, one for Moses, and one for Elijah." 6 He hardly knew how
to respond, since they were frightened. 7 Then a cloud came and cast
its shadow over them, and a voice came out of the cloud: "This is my
Son, the one I love. Listen to him!"[e] 8 All at once, looking about them,
they saw nobody there anymore, only Jesus by himself with them.
9 As they were coming down the mountain, he instructed them to
tell nobody what they had seen until the Son of Man had risen from
the dead. 10 They kept the matter to themselves, debating among
themselves what this "rising from the dead" might mean. 11 And they
put a question to him: "Why do the scribes say that Elijah must come
first?"[f] 12 He answered, "Elijah does come first, to set everything right.
But why then is it written about the Son of Man that he must endure
great suffering and be rejected?[g] 13 I assure you, Elijah has already
come, and people treated him however they liked, exactly as the
Scriptures say of him."
14 On reaching the rest of the disciples, they found a big crowd
surrounding them, and scribes engaged in debate with them. 15 As
soon as the crowd saw Jesus, they were all overcome with amazement
and ran up to greet him. 16 "What is this dispute you are having
with them?" he asked. 17 A man from the crowd replied, "Teacher, I
have brought you my boy. A spirit has taken his speech from him. 18
Whenever it takes hold of him, it hurls him to the ground; he foams at
the mouth, grinds his teeth, and becomes rigid. I asked your disciples
to cast it out, but they did not have the power." 19 Jesus responded,
"Faithless generation! How much longer am I to be among you? How
much longer must I bear with you? Bring the boy here to me." 20 So
they brought the boy. As soon as the spirit caught sight of Jesus, it
shook the child violently, and he dropped to the ground and kept
rolling around, frothing at the mouth. 21 Jesus questioned the boy's
father: "For how long has this been going on?" He replied, "From
childhood. 22 "Many times it has thrown him into fire or into water to
destroy him. But if you are able to do anything, take pity on us and
help us!" 23 Jesus replied, " 'If you are able'?[h] For someone who trusts,
nothing is impossible." 24 Immediately the boy's father shouted, "I do
believe! Come to the aid of my lack of faith!" 25 Seeing that a crowd

was rushing toward them, Jesus scolded the unclean spirit: “Deaf and mute spirit, I order you: leave him, and do not ever go into him again!”
26 The spirit shrieked, threw the boy into fierce spasms, and left him.
He lay there like a dead body, so that most of the people said he had
died. 27 But Jesus took him by the hand and lifted him, and he stood
up. 28 After he had entered a house, his disciples asked him in private,
“Why were we unable to expel it?” 29 He said to them, “Only prayer
can drive out this sort.”[i]
30 Leaving that district, they traveled on through Galilee, and he
wished nobody to find out, 31 since he was instructing his disciples.
“The Son of Man,” he told them, “is to be delivered into the hands of
men; they will put him to death, and when he has been killed, on the
third day after, he will rise.” 32 But what he was saying was beyond
them, and they were afraid to question him about it.
33 They arrived at Capernaum. Once inside the house, he asked them,
“What were you arguing about on the way?” 34 They were silent, since
along the way they had been disputing with each other over which
of them was greatest. 35 Sitting down, he called the Twelve and told
them, “Anyone who wishes to come first must take the last place of
all and be the servant of everyone.” 36 Then he took a little child and
stood the child among them; and taking the child in his arms, he said
to them, 37 “Anyone who receives a child like this one in my name is
receiving me; and anyone who receives me is receiving, not me, but
the One who sent me.”
38 John said to him, “Teacher, we came across a man driving out
demons by using your name, and we kept trying to prevent him, since
he was not one of our followers.” 39 Jesus answered, “Do not hinder
him. Nobody who performs a miracle in my name will be quick to
speak badly of me afterward. 40 For whoever is not against us is for us.
41 Truly I tell you, whoever hands you a drink of water because you
are Christ’s will by no means forfeit a reward.
42 “Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me[j] to fall
into sin would do better to have a huge millstone[k] tied around the
neck and be thrown into the sea. 43 Should your hand trip you up, cut
it off. Better that you go into life crippled than keep both hands and

depart into Gehenna,[l] to the fire nothing can put out. [44] [m] [45] And should your foot trip you up, cut it off. Better that you go into life limping than keep both feet and be cast into Gehenna. [46] [n] [47] And should your eye trip you up, pull it out. Better that you go into God's kingdom one-eyed than keep both eyes and be cast into Gehenna, [48] where the worm that feeds on them never dies, and the fire never goes out.[o] [49] For everyone will be salted with fire.[p] [50] Salt is fine. But if it goes flat, how can you restore its flavor? Keep salt among yourselves, and live in peace with each other."

Notes

- a (9:2) His appearance was changed: Greek *metamorphōthē*, traditionally "transfigured."
- b (9:3) Bleacher: Greek *gnapheus*, a fuller, who cleaned and whitened cloth.
- c (9:4) Elijah … Moses: representing the Prophets and the Law. *Moses* is explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out."
- d (9:5) Rabbi: Hebrew, "my great one," "my master," a respectful title for a teacher.
- e (9:7) Ps 2:7; Deut 18:15; compare Isa 42:1.
- f (9:11) Mal 4:5–6 (3:23–24 in Hebrew).
- g (9:12) Compare Isa 53:3; Ps 22:6–7.
- h (9:23) 'If you are able'!: Jesus repeats the father's words. Many later manuscripts read "If you can believe, all things are possible to one who believes."
- i (9:29) Through prayer: many manuscripts add "and fasting"; the Westcott–Hort text, with the first hand of Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks the words.
- j (9:42) Who believe: many manuscripts add "in me."
- k (9:42) A great millstone: literally "a donkey's millstone," the large upper stone of a mill turned by a donkey.
- l (9:43) Gehenna: Greek form of Hebrew *Ge-Hinnom*, "Valley of Hinnom," a ravine south of Jerusalem once used for child sacrifice (Jer 7:31) and later a symbol of the place of final judgment. In verse 45 many manuscripts add "into the fire nothing can put out."
- m (9:44) Verse 44 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and others). Many later manuscripts add, "where their worm does not die and the fire is not quenched," repeated from verse 48.
- n (9:46) Verse 46 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts. Many later manuscripts repeat verse 48 here as well ("where their worm does not die and the fire is not quenched").
- o (9:48) Isa 66:24.
- p (9:49) Many manuscripts add "and every sacrifice will be salted with salt" (compare Lev 2:13); Codex Bezae has this clause instead of the other. The Westcott–Hort text has the shorter reading.

Chapter 10

1 Setting out from there, Jesus went into the territory of Judea and
beyond the Jordan.[a] Again crowds gathered to him, and as was his
habit, he taught them once more. 2 Some Pharisees[b] came up and, to
test him, asked whether a man is permitted to divorce his wife. 3 He
answered by asking, "What instruction did Moses give you?" 4 They
said, "Moses allowed a man to write out a certificate of divorce and
send her away."[c] 5 Jesus told them, "It was because your hearts were
hard that he wrote you this command. 6 But from the start of creation,
'male and female he made them.'[d] 7 'For this reason a man will leave
his father and mother,[e] 8 and the two will become one flesh.' So they
are two no longer, but a single flesh. 9 What God has yoked together,
then, no human being should split apart." 10 Once they were indoors
again, the disciples asked him about it. 11 He said to them, "Any man
who divorces his wife and weds another woman commits adultery
against her; 12 and if she divorces her husband and weds another man,
she commits adultery."

13 People kept bringing little children to Jesus for him to touch, but
the disciples scolded them. 14 When Jesus saw this, he was indignant.
"Let the little children come to me," he told them. "Do not hold them
back, for God's kingdom belongs to such as these. 15 Amen, I tell you,
anyone who will not receive God's kingdom as a little child receives
it will never get into it." 16 And he gathered them into his arms and
blessed them, laying his hands on them.

17 As Jesus was starting out on his way, a man ran up, knelt in front of
him, and asked, "Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit everlasting
life?" 18 "Why call me good?" Jesus replied. "Nobody is good except
one—God. 19 You know the commands: 'You shall not kill; you shall
not commit adultery; you shall not steal; you shall not give false
evidence; you shall not defraud; respect your father and mother.' "[f] 20
"Teacher," he said, "I have kept all of these since I was young." 21 Jesus
fixed his eyes on him and loved him. "One thing you still lack," he told
him. "Go, sell whatever you possess and give to the poor, and you will
have treasure in heaven. Then come, follow me." 22 At these words the
man's face fell, and he went off grieving, for he owned great estates.

23 Jesus looked around and said to his disciples, “How hard it will
be for the wealthy to enter God’s kingdom!” 24 The disciples were
startled at his words. But Jesus said to them again, “Children, how
hard it is to enter God’s kingdom![g] 25 A camel can squeeze through
the eye of a needle more easily than a wealthy person can enter the
kingdom of God.” 26 They were astonished beyond measure and said
to one another, “Then who can be saved?” 27 Jesus gazed at them and
said, “For mortals this cannot be done, but not for God; everything
is possible for God.”[h] 28 Peter started to say to him, “Consider that
we have left everything behind and have followed you.” 29 Jesus said,
“Amen, I tell you, there is no one who has left house or brothers or
sisters or mother or father or children or fields for my sake and for
the gospel 30 will receive a hundredfold now, in this very age—houses,
brothers and sisters, mothers and children, and farms, though with
persecutions—and, in the age to come, life without end. 31 But many
who are first will be last, and the last will be first.”
32 They were traveling the road up to Jerusalem, and Jesus was in front.
The disciples were amazed, and those trailing behind were fearful.
Again he took the Twelve apart from the others and began to explain
what would happen to him. 33 “Listen,” he said, “we are going up to
Jerusalem, and the Son of Man will be handed over to the chief priests
and the scribes. They will condemn him to death and hand him over
to the Gentiles, 34 They will mock him, spit on him, flog him and kill
him, and after three days he will rise.”
35 Then James and John, Zebedee’s sons, approached him. “Teacher,”
they said, “we want you to do for us whatever we ask of you.” 36
“What do you want me to do for you?” he asked them. 37 They replied,
“Allow us to sit with you in your glory, one at your right hand and
one at your left.” 38 Jesus said to them, “You have no idea what you are
asking. Can you drink the cup I am drinking, or be baptized with the
baptism I am being baptized with?”[i] 39 “We are able,” they answered.
Then Jesus told them, “You will drink the cup that I drink, and you
will undergo the baptism that I undergo; 40 but who sits at my right
or my left is not for me to grant; those places belong to the ones for
whom they are prepared.” 41 When the ten heard about it, they began

to be indignant with James and John. 42 Jesus called them together and said to them, "You know that those regarded as rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and their great ones exercise power over them. 43 It is not to be that way among you. Instead, anyone who wants to become great among you must be your servant, 44 and whoever would hold first place among you is to be everybody's slave. 45 For the Son of Man himself did not come to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom[j] for many."

46 They came to Jericho.[k] As Jesus was leaving Jericho with his disciples and a sizable crowd, the son of Timaeus, Bartimaeus,[l] a blind beggar, was sitting beside the road. 47 Hearing that it was Jesus of Nazareth,[m] he began to shout, "Son of David,[n] Jesus, have mercy on me!" 48 Many rebuked him, telling him to keep quiet, but he only cried out more loudly, "Son of David, take pity on me!" 49 Jesus stopped and said, "Call him." So they called the blind man, saying, "Cheer up! Get up—he is calling you." 50 He threw off his cloak, jumped to his feet, and went to Jesus. 51 Jesus asked him, "What do you want me to do for you?" The blind man said, "Rabbouni,[o] let me see again." 52 Jesus told him, "Go; your faith has made you well." Instantly he could see, and he followed Jesus along the road.

Notes

- a (10:1) Beyond the Jordan: that is, Perea, east of the river. Many manuscripts read "by way of the far side of the Jordan."
- b (10:2) Some Pharisees: the words are bracketed by Westcott–Hort; Codex Bezae and some Old Latin manuscripts lack them, giving "people asked him."
- c (10:4) Deut 24:1–4.
- d (10:6) Gen 1:27; 5:2.
- e (10:7) Gen 2:24. Many manuscripts add "and be united to his wife"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks the words.
- f (10:19) Exod 20:12–16; Deut 5:16–20. *Do not cheat* may reflect Deut 24:14 or Exod 20:17.
- g (10:24) Many manuscripts read "how hard it is for those who trust in riches to enter God's kingdom"; the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks the phrase.
- h (10:27) Compare Gen 18:14; Job 42:2.
- i (10:38) The cup … the baptism: images for suffering and death (compare 14:36; Ps 75:8; Isa 51:17).

- j (10:45) Ransom: Greek *lytron*, the price paid to free a slave or captive. Compare Isa 53:10–12.
- k (10:46) Jericho: Hebrew *Yericho*, perhaps "moon city" or "fragrant place," about 15 miles (24 km) northeast of Jerusalem.
- l (10:46) Bartimaeus: Aramaic *bar Timai*, "son of Timaeus," as Mark explains. *Timaeus* may come from Greek *timē*, "honor," or from Aramaic, "unclean," "defiled."
- m (10:47) Jesus of Nazareth: literally "the Nazarene."
- n (10:47) Son of David: a messianic title (2 Sam 7:12–16; Isa 11:1).
- o (10:51) Rabbouni: Aramaic, "my master," "my teacher," a more emphatic form of Rabbi.

Chapter 11

1 As they drew close to Jerusalem, near Bethphage[a] and Bethany[b] at
the Mount of Olives,[c] Jesus sent off two of his disciples
2 telling them, "Go to the village opposite you. Just as you go in, you
will come upon a young donkey tethered there, one nobody has yet
sat on. Untie it and lead it here.
3 If anybody asks you, 'Why are you doing that?' say, 'The Lord[d] needs
it, and he will send it back here without delay.' "
4 Off they went, and they came upon a colt tethered by a doorway out
on the street, and they set it loose.
5 Some of the bystanders said to them, "What do you mean by untying
that colt?"
6 They answered as Jesus had told them, and the people let them go.
7 Then they led the colt to Jesus, laid their cloaks over it, and Jesus
mounted it.
8 Many people laid their coats along the road, and others strewed
branches cut from the fields.
9 The people in front and the people behind were crying out,
"Hosanna![e]
Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord![f]
10 Blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David!
Hosanna in the highest heaven!"
11 Entering Jerusalem, he went to the temple and surveyed everything
there; then, because the hour was late, he went back out with the
Twelve to Bethany.

12 On the following day, when they had left Bethany, he felt hungry.
13 Seeing in the distance a fig tree in leaf, he went to check whether
it had any fruit. When he reached it he found only foliage, for the
season for figs had not yet come.[g] 14 He said to the tree, "Let no one
eat your fruit ever again." His disciples were listening.
15 They reached Jerusalem, and Jesus entered the temple precincts and
started to expel the sellers and buyers who were doing business there.
He knocked over the tables of the money changers[h] and the benches
of the dove sellers, 16 and he would not allow anyone to carry goods
through the temple courts. 17 He taught them: "Does Scripture not
say, 'My house shall be called a house of prayer for every nation'?[i]
Yet you have made it a robbers' den."[j] 18 The chief priests and scribes
learned of this and searched for some means of doing away with him.
They were afraid of him, for the entire crowd was astonished at his
teaching. 19 And each evening they[k] would leave the city.
20 Early in the morning, as they passed by, they saw the fig tree
withered from the roots up. 21 Peter remembered and said to him,
"Rabbi, look! The fig tree you cursed has withered." 22 Jesus answered
them, "Have faith in God.[l] 23 Amen, I tell you, should anyone say to
this mountain, 'Rise up and hurl yourself into the sea,' and have no
doubt in his heart, but trust that what he says is happening, it will
be so for him. 24 For this reason I say to you: whatever you ask for in
prayer, believe that you have already received it, and it will be yours.
25 And whenever you stand up to pray, forgive whatever grievance
you have against someone, so that your Father in heaven may also
forgive your wrongdoings." 26 [m]
27 Once more they arrived in Jerusalem. While Jesus was strolling in
the temple precincts, the chief priests, scribes, and elders approached
him 28 They asked him, "On what authority do you do these things?
Or who authorized you to do them?" 29 Jesus said to them, "I will ask
you one question. Answer me, and I will tell you on what authority I
act in this way. 30 John's baptism—was it from heaven or from human
beings? Answer me." 31 They argued among themselves, "If we say,
'From heaven,' he will say, 'Then why did you not believe him?' 32
But should we say, 'From human beings'?"—they were afraid of the

people, for everyone held that John had truly been a prophet. [33] So their answer to Jesus was, "We cannot say." Jesus replied, "Then I will not tell you either on what authority I am doing these things."

Notes

- a (11:1) Bethphage: Aramaic, "house of unripe figs," a village on the Mount of Olives.
- b (11:1) Bethany: perhaps "house of the poor" or "house of Ananiah," a village about 2 miles (3 km) east of Jerusalem.
- c (11:1) Mount of Olives: the ridge east of Jerusalem across the Kidron Valley (compare Zech 14:4).
- d (11:3) The Lord: or "its master." The Greek *kyrios* can mean "Lord" or "owner."
- e (11:9) Hosanna: Hebrew *hoshi'ah na*, "save, please!" (Ps 118:25), which had become a shout of praise.
- f (11:9) Ps 118:26. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- g (11:13) Compare Jer 8:13; Hos 9:10; Mic 7:1.
- h (11:15) Money changers: they exchanged foreign coins for the Tyrian silver coins required for paying the temple tax.
- i (11:17) Isa 56:7. *All the nations*: or "all the Gentiles."
- j (11:17) Jer 7:11. *Hideout for robbers*: literally "a cave of bandits."
- k (11:19) They: Alexandrinus, Vaticanus and some others, followed by Westcott–Hort, read "they"; Sinaiticus and many manuscripts read "he."
- l (11:22) Have faith in God: or "Have the faith that comes from God." Sinaiticus, Bezae and a few others read "If you have faith in God."
- m (11:26) Verse 26 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and in the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and others). Many later manuscripts add, "But if you do not forgive, neither will your Father in heaven forgive your wrongdoings" (compare Matt 6:15).

Chapter 12

[1] Then he began to speak to them in parables: "A man planted a vineyard, put a wall around it, dug a pit for the winepress, and built a watchtower.[a] He leased it to tenant farmers and went abroad.

[2] At harvest time he dispatched a slave to the farmers to receive his share of the grapes from them.

[3] But they grabbed him, beat him, and sent him off with nothing.

[4] Again he sent them another slave. This one they struck on the head and treated shamefully.

[5] He sent still another, and that one they murdered. He sent many more; some they beat and some they killed.

6 He still had one left to send, a son he dearly loved. Last of all he sent
him to them, thinking, 'They will have regard for my son.'
7 But those tenants said to one another, 'Here is the heir! Come on,
we will kill him, and the inheritance will belong to us.'
8 So they seized him and killed him, and flung him outside the
vineyard.
9 What then will the vineyard's owner do? He will come and destroy
those tenants, and hand the vineyard over to others.
10 Have you never read this scripture:
'The stone the builders rejected as worthless
has turned out to be the chief cornerstone.
11 This came about from the Lord,[b]
and it is a marvel in our eyes'?"[c]
12 They were looking for a way to lay hands on him, for they knew
the parable had been told against them; yet they feared the crowd. So
they let him be and departed.
13 Next they sent to him some of the Pharisees and Herodians,[d] to catch
him out in something he said. 14 They came to him and said, "Teacher,
we know you are truthful and do not bow to anyone, since you pay
no attention to a person's status but teach God's way truthfully. Does
the Law permit paying the census tax[e] to Caesar, or not? Are we to
pay or not to pay?" 15 Seeing through their pretense, he replied, "Why
are you testing me? Fetch me a silver coin[f] and let me have a look."
16 They brought one, and he asked them, "Whose likeness is this, and
whose inscription?" "Caesar's," they told him. 17 Jesus said to them,
"What belongs to Caesar, give back to Caesar, and what belongs to
God, give to God." And they were utterly amazed at him.
18 Then some Sadducees[g] came to him—the people who say there is
no resurrection—and put a question to him. 19 "Teacher," they said,
"Moses laid down for us in writing: should a man die childless, leaving
a widow, his brother is to marry her and produce descendants for the
dead man.[h] 20 Now there were seven brothers. The first took a wife
and died without leaving any children. 21 The second took her, and
he too died leaving no children; the third likewise. 22 Not one of the
seven had children by her. Finally the woman herself died. 23 In the

resurrection, when they rise, whose wife will she be? The seven of them all had her as wife." 24 Jesus told them, "Surely this is why you are wrong: you are ignorant both of the scriptures and of the power of God. 25 For when people rise from among the dead, men do not marry and women are not given in marriage; they are like the angels in heaven. 26 And as for the dead being raised, have you not read in the book of Moses, in the passage about the bush,[i] how God spoke to him, saying, 'I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob'?[j] 27 He is not God of corpses but of the living. You are badly mistaken."

28 One of the scribes came up and heard them debating. Seeing that Jesus had answered them well, he asked him, "Which commandment ranks first of all?" 29 Jesus answered, "The first is this: 'Hear, Israel: the Lord our God, the Lord is one.[k] 30 love the Lord[l] your God with your whole heart, your whole soul, your whole mind and your whole strength.'[m] 31 The second is this: 'You shall love your neighbor as you love yourself.'[n] No other commandment is greater than these." 32 The scribe said to him, "Teacher, you have spoken well. You are right that God is one and there is no other besides him, 33 And to love him with one's whole heart, whole understanding, and whole strength, and to love one's neighbor as oneself, outweighs all the whole burnt offerings and sacrifices."[o] 34 When Jesus saw how thoughtfully he had replied, he said to him, "You are not far from God's kingdom." And after that nobody dared to question him any more.

35 While teaching in the temple, Jesus took up the matter and asked, "How can the scribes claim that the Messiah is David's son?

36 It was David himself who said, moved by the Holy Spirit:

'The Lord said to my lord,
"Take your seat at my right hand
until I put your enemies beneath your feet." '[p]

37 David himself calls him 'lord'; so how can he be his son?" And the great crowd listened to him with delight.

38 In his teaching he said, "Be on your guard against the scribes, who like to parade about in long robes and to be greeted with deference in the marketplaces, 39 and who want the chief seats in the synagogues

and the places of honor at banquets. [40] They swallow up widows' houses and, for show, pray at great length. These will receive the heavier sentence."

[41] He sat down across from the treasury[q] and watched how the crowd dropped money into the offering chests. Many rich people were putting in large sums. [42] Then a poor widow came and dropped in two tiny copper coins, together worth only a sixty-fourth of a day's wage.[r] [43] He called the disciples over and told them, "Amen, I say to you: more has gone into the treasury from this destitute widow than from all the rest. [44] For they all gave out of their surplus, but she, out of her want, put in everything she possessed—all she had to live on."

Notes

- a (12:1) Vineyard ... lookout tower: the description echoes Isa 5:1–2.
- b (12:11) The Lord: Greek *kyrios*; in Ps 118:23 the Hebrew has the divine name, Yahweh.
- c (12:11) Ps 118:22–23.
- d (12:13) Herodians: supporters of the dynasty of Herod, here allied with the Pharisees as in 3:6.
- e (12:14) Poll tax: Greek *kēnsos* (Latin *census*), the head tax paid directly to Rome.
- f (12:15) Silver coin: Greek *dēnarion*, the Roman denarius, a day's wage for a laborer, bearing the emperor's image.
- g (12:18) Sadducees: a priestly party that accepted only the written law as binding and denied the resurrection; the name is probably derived from Zadok, the priest of David and Solomon (2 Sam 8:17).
- h (12:19) Deut 25:5–6 (levirate marriage); compare Gen 38:8.
- i (12:26) The bush: Exod 3:1–6, the burning bush.
- j (12:26) Exod 3:6, 15.
- k (12:29) Deut 6:4, the *Shema* (from its first word, "Hear"). Both occurrences of "Lord" stand for the divine name, Yahweh, in the Hebrew. *Israel* means "he strives with God" (Gen 32:28).
- l (12:30) The Lord: in Deut 6:5 the Hebrew has Yahweh.
- m (12:30) Deut 6:5. Mark lists four faculties (heart, soul, mind, strength) where the Hebrew has three.
- n (12:31) Lev 19:18.
- o (12:33) Compare 1 Sam 15:22; Hos 6:6.
- p (12:36) Ps 110:1. The first "Lord" stands for the divine name, Yahweh, in the Hebrew; the second ("my lord") translates *adoni*, a title of honor.

- q (12:41) Treasury: the thirteen trumpet-shaped offering chests in the Court of the Women.
- r (12:42) Two tiny copper coins: Greek *lepta duo*, "two lepta," the smallest copper coins in circulation; Mark adds, "which make a *kodrantēs*" (Latin *quadrans*), one sixty-fourth of a denarius, the denarius being a laborer's day's wage.

Chapter 13

1 As he was leaving the temple, one of his disciples said to him,
"Teacher, look! What enormous stones, what splendid buildings!" 2
Jesus answered him, "You see these great structures? Not a single
stone will be left here upon another; every one will be pulled down."
3 Peter, James, John and Andrew asked him privately as he was sitting
on the Mount of Olives opposite the temple: 4 "Tell us, when is this to
happen? And what will be the signal that all these things are about
to reach their completion?" 5 Jesus began to tell them, "Take care that
nobody leads you astray. 6 Many will come using my name, claiming,
'I am he,'[a] and they will lead many astray. 7 When you hear the noise
of battles and rumors of wars, do not be alarmed. These things have
to happen, but that is not yet the finish. 8 One nation will rise against
another, and one kingdom against another. There will be earthquakes
in many places, and famines. These things are just the beginning of
the labor pains.
9 "As for you, be on your guard. They will hand you over to councils,[b]
and you will be flogged in synagogues; you will stand before gover-
nors and kings on my account, to bear witness to them. 10 And first the
good news must be proclaimed among all the nations. 11 Whenever
they arrest you and bring you to trial, do not fret beforehand about
what you will say; just say whatever is given you at that moment,
for it is not you who speak but the Holy Spirit. 12 Brothers will betray
brothers to death, and fathers their children; children will rise against
parents and have them put to death. 13 Everyone will hate you because
of my name. But whoever holds out to the end will be saved.
14 "When you see the desolating abomination[c] standing where he
ought not to be—let the reader take note—then those in Judea must
escape to the hills. 15 Anyone on the rooftop must not go down or
go inside to fetch anything out of the house; 16 anyone out in the

field must not turn back to pick up a cloak. 17 How hard it will be in
those days for women expecting a child and for mothers with babies
at the breast! 18 Pray that it does not happen in winter. 19 For those
days will bring distress such as has never been from the beginning
of the creation God made until now, and never will be again. 20 Had
the Lord not cut short those days, no living being would survive; but
for the sake of the chosen, whom he has chosen for himself, he has
cut the days short. 21 And at that time, if anyone says to you, 'Look,
the Messiah is here!' or 'Look, he is there!' do not believe it. 22 For
pretended messiahs and pretended prophets will arise and work signs
and marvels, aiming to deceive even the chosen, were that possible.
23 So keep watch; I have forewarned you of everything.
24 "But in those days, after that time of distress,
'the sun will grow dark,
and the moon will not shed its light;
25 the stars will be falling out of the sky,
and the powers in the heavens will be shaken.'[d]
26 Then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds[e] with great
power and glory.
27 And then he will send out the angels and gather [his] chosen ones
from the four winds, from the farthest edge of the earth to the farthest
edge of the sky.
28 "Learn the lesson from the fig tree. As soon as its branch turns
tender and puts out leaves, you know summer is close. 29 So it is with
you: when you see these things taking place, know that he[f] is near,
right at the doors. 30 Amen, I tell you, this generation will not pass
away before all these things have happened. 31 Sky and earth will pass
away, but my words will never pass away.
32 "But that day or hour nobody knows—not the angels in heaven, nor
the Son,[g] but only the Father. 33 Be on the lookout and keep alert, since
the appointed moment is unknown to you.[h] 34 It is like a man away on
a journey, who leaves his house and puts his slaves in charge, each
with his own task, and orders the doorkeeper to keep awake. 35 Stay
awake, then, because the master of the house may return at any time
unknown to you—late in the evening, at midnight, at cockcrow, or

early in the morning.[i] 36 Otherwise he may come without warning and
find you sleeping. 37 What I say to you I say to everyone: Keep awake!"

Notes

- a (13:6) I am he: literally "I am," perhaps echoing the divine self-designation (Exod 3:14; Isa 43:10).
- b (13:9) Councils: Greek *synedria*, local Jewish courts.
- c (13:14) Desolating abomination: literally "the abomination of desolation," Dan 9:27; 11:31; 12:11; compare 1 Macc 1:54. The participle "standing" is masculine, suggesting a person.
- d (13:25) Isa 13:10; 34:4; compare Joel 2:10.
- e (13:26) Coming in clouds: Dan 7:13.
- f (13:29) He: or "it."
- g (13:32) Nor the Son: these words, present in all the major manuscripts of Mark, are omitted in some late manuscripts of Matt 24:36.
- h (13:33) The appointed moment is unknown to you: literally "you do not know when the time is"; Westcott–Hort bracket "is" (*estin*). Many manuscripts add "and pray" after "keep alert" (Sinaiticus and others); Vaticanus and Bezae lack it.
- i (13:35) Late in the evening … early in the morning: the four Roman watches of the night, roughly six to nine in the evening, nine to midnight, midnight to three, and three to six in the morning.

Chapter 14

1 Two days remained until the Passover and the feast of Unleavened
Bread.[a] Meanwhile the chief priests and scribes were seeking a way
to seize Jesus by a trick and put him to death. 2 For they said, "Not at
the feast, in case there is an uproar among the people."
3 He was at Bethany in the house of Simon the leper,[b] sitting at the
table, when a woman arrived with an alabaster jar of very expensive
perfume, pure nard.[c] She broke the jar open and poured the perfume
on his head. 4 Some of those present grumbled indignantly to one
another, "What was the point of squandering the ointment like this?
5 It could have been sold for over three hundred days' wages[d] and the
money given to the poor." And they spoke sharply to her. 6 But Jesus
said, "Leave her alone. Why are you making trouble for her? She has
done a beautiful thing for me. 7 The poor you always have among
you, and you can do good to them [always] whenever you wish; but
me you will not always have. 8 She has done what lay in her power:
she has anointed my body ahead of time for its burial. 9 Amen, I tell

you, in every part of the world where the good news is preached, her deed too will be spoken of, so that she is remembered."
10 Judas Iscariot,[e] who was one of the Twelve, went to the chief priests
in order to hand Jesus over to them. 11 They were delighted to hear it
and promised to pay him in silver. So he kept looking for a convenient
opportunity to hand him over.
12 On the first day of the Unleavened Bread, the day the Passover lambs
were slaughtered, his disciples said to him, "Where would you like
us to go and get things ready for you to eat the Passover meal?" 13 He
sent two of his disciples with these instructions: "Go into the city, and
a man carrying a clay jar of water will meet you. Follow him, 14 and
whatever house he enters, tell its master, 'The Teacher says: Where is
the room set aside for me, so that I can eat the Passover there with my
disciples?' 15 He himself will point out to you a spacious room upstairs,
already furnished with couches. Get things ready for us there." 16 The
disciples set out, came into the city, and found everything just as he
had told them; and they prepared the Passover.
17 When evening came, he arrived with the Twelve. 18 And as they
reclined at the meal, Jesus said, "Amen, I tell you, one of you will
betray me—one who is eating with me."[f] 19 Grief came over them, and
one after another they began asking him, "Surely not I?" 20 He told
them, "It is one of the Twelve, one who is dipping his bread with me
into the [one] bowl. 21 The Son of Man will go as the Scriptures say
about him; but how terrible for the one by whom the Son of Man is
handed over! It would have been better for that man never to have
been born."
22 While they were eating, he took a loaf, said the blessing, broke it,
and gave it to them with the words, "Take it; this is my body."[g] 23 Then
he took a cup, gave thanks, and handed it to them, and they all drank
from it. 24 And he told them, "This is my blood of the covenant,[h] poured
out on behalf of many. 25 Amen, I tell you, never again will I drink
of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new in God's
kingdom."
26 After singing the hymn,[i] they went out to the Mount of Olives.

27 And Jesus told them, “All of you will stumble and fall away, because
Scripture says:
‘I will strike down the shepherd,
and the sheep will be scattered.’[j]
28 But once I am raised, I will lead the way before you into Galilee.”
29 Peter declared, “Everyone else may fall away, but not I.”
30 Jesus said to him, “Amen, I tell you: this very night, before a rooster
crows twice, you will deny me three times.”
31 But Peter kept protesting all the more forcefully, “Even if it means
dying alongside you, I will not disown you!” And all of them were
saying the same.
32 They went to a place named Gethsemane,[k] and he said to his
disciples, “Stay here while I pray.” 33 Taking with him Peter, James,
and John, he began to be filled with alarm and anguish. 34 “My soul is
crushed with grief, even to death,”[l] he told them. “Wait here and stay
awake.” 35 Going on a little farther, he fell to the ground and prayed
that, if it were possible, the hour might pass him by. 36 “Abba,[m] Father,”
he said, “for you all things are possible. Take this cup away from me.
Yet let it be not what I want, but what you want.” 37 He came back
and found them asleep. “Simon,” he said to Peter, “are you sleeping?
Had you not the strength to stay awake a single hour? 38 Keep awake
and pray, so that you do not come into the time of testing.[n] The spirit
is eager, but human nature is frail.” 39 Once more he went away and
prayed, [saying the same words.] 40 And again he came and found
them sleeping, for their eyes were weighed down; and they had no
idea what to say to him. 41 Coming back a third time, he said to them,
“Still asleep? Still taking your rest?[o] It is enough; the hour is here.
See, the Son of Man is being betrayed into sinners’ hands. 42 Get up,
let us go. Look, the one betraying me is close at hand.”
43 And just then, as he was speaking, up came Judas, one of the
Twelve, with a mob carrying swords and cudgels, dispatched by the
chief priests, scribes, and elders. 44 His betrayer had given them a
prearranged sign: “The man I kiss—he is the one. Take hold of him
and lead him off securely.” 45 As soon as he arrived, he went straight
up to Jesus, said, “Rabbi!” and kissed him warmly. 46 Then they laid

hands on him and arrested him. 47 One of those standing nearby drew
a sword and slashed at the high priest's slave, slicing off his ear. 48 Jesus
responded, "Have you come out with swords and cudgels to capture
me as though I were a bandit? 49 Every day I was among you in the
temple teaching, and you never arrested me. But this is happening so
that the Scriptures will be fulfilled." 50 Then they all deserted him and
ran away.
51 A young man was following him, wearing only a linen cloth over
his naked body. They seized him, 52 but he left the linen cloth behind
and fled naked.[p]
53 They took Jesus away to the high priest,[q] and all the chief priests, el-
ders, and scribes assembled. 54 Peter trailed behind at a distance, as far
as the inside of the high priest's courtyard, and he was sitting among
the attendants, keeping warm by the blaze. 55 Meanwhile the chief
priests and the entire Council[r] kept searching for evidence against
Jesus that would justify putting him to death, yet they could find
none. 56 Many gave false evidence against him, but their statements
did not agree. 57 Some men then rose and testified falsely against him,
saying, 58 "We ourselves heard him say, 'I will pull down this temple
made with hands, and within three days I will build another, not made
with hands.' " 59 But even so, their accounts were inconsistent. 60 Then
the high priest stood up in their midst and questioned Jesus: "Have
you no answer to make? What is this testimony these men bring
against you?" 61 He kept silent and said nothing in reply. Once more
the high priest put a question to him: "Are you the Christ, the Son of
the Blessed?"[s] 62 "I am," said Jesus, "and you will see the Son of Man
seated at the right hand of the Power[t] and coming with the clouds of
heaven."[u] 63 At that the high priest ripped his garments. "What further
need have we of witnesses?" he said. 64 "You heard him blaspheme.
How does it seem to you?" And all of them judged him worthy of
death. 65 Then some started spitting at him; they covered his face,
punched him, and taunted him, "Prophesy!" And the attendants took
him and slapped him.
66 Peter was down in the courtyard when one of the high priest's
maidservants came along. 67 Noticing Peter warming himself, she

looked closely at him and said, “You too were with the Nazarene, this Jesus.” 68 But he denied it: “I have no idea what you mean—I don’t understand it.” And he went outside into the entryway.[v] 69 The servant girl saw him there and began telling the bystanders once more, “This fellow is one of them.” 70 Again he denied it. A little while afterward the bystanders said to Peter again, “You certainly are one of them, for you are a Galilean.”[w] 71 Then he began to put himself under a curse and to swear, “I have no knowledge of this man you speak of.” 72 And right then the rooster crowed for the second time, and Peter recalled the word Jesus had spoken to him: “Twice the rooster will crow, and before that you will have disowned me three times.” And he broke down and wept.[x]

Notes

- a (14:1) Passover … Unleavened Bread: the Passover meal on the evening beginning 15 Nisan, followed by the seven-day festival of Unleavened Bread (Exod 12:1–20; Lev 23:5–8).
- b (14:3) Simon the leper: presumably a man Jesus had healed. *Simon* means “he has heard.”
- c (14:3) Pure nard: Greek *nardou pistikēs*, spikenard, an aromatic oil imported from the Himalayas; *pistikēs* probably means “genuine.”
- d (14:5) More than three hundred days’ wages: literally “more than three hundred denarii,” a denarius being a laborer’s day’s wage.
- e (14:10) Iscariot: probably Hebrew *ish Qeriyot*, “man of Kerioth,” a town in Judea (Josh 15:25).
- f (14:18) Eating with me: compare Ps 41:9.
- g (14:22) This is my body: Westcott–Hort and the earliest manuscripts lack “eat” after “take it,” which many later manuscripts add (compare Matt 26:26).
- h (14:24) Blood of the covenant: Exod 24:8; compare Zech 9:11. Many manuscripts read “the new covenant” (compare Luke 22:20; 1 Cor 11:25); Westcott–Hort, following Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lack “new.”
- i (14:26) The hymn: probably the second half of the Hallel (Pss 115–118), sung at the close of the Passover meal.
- j (14:27) Zech 13:7.
- k (14:32) Gethsemane: Aramaic *gat shemanim*, “oil press.”
- l (14:34) Ps 42:5, 11; 43:5.
- m (14:36) Abba: Aramaic for “father,” the intimate address of a child to a parent; compare Rom 8:15; Gal 4:6.
- n (14:38) Time of testing: or “temptation.”

- o (14:41) Still asleep? Still taking your rest?: or, as a command, “Sleep on now and take your rest.” *It is enough*: Greek *apechei*, of uncertain meaning; perhaps “the account is settled,” “he (the betrayer) has received payment,” or “it is far off.” Bezae and some others add “the end.”
- p (14:52) Fled naked: this episode is found only in Mark. Some have suggested the young man was Mark himself, but this is conjecture.
- q (14:53) The high priest: Caiaphas (Matt 26:57), high priest AD 18–36.
- r (14:55) Council: Greek *synedrion*, the Sanhedrin, the supreme Jewish court in Jerusalem, presided over by the high priest.
- s (14:61) The Blessed: a reverent Jewish substitute for the name of God.
- t (14:62) The Power: another reverent substitute for the name of God. The words echo Ps 110:1.
- u (14:62) Dan 7:13.
- v (14:68) Entryway: or “forecourt.” Many manuscripts add “and a rooster crowed” (Alexandrinus, Bezae and others); Westcott–Hort, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lack it.
- w (14:70) Galilean: many later manuscripts add “and your speech gives you away” (compare Matt 26:73).
- x (14:72) He broke down and wept: the meaning of the Greek *epibalōn* is uncertain; perhaps “he thought of it,” “he threw himself down,” or “he covered his head.”

Chapter 15

1 Early in the morning, the chief priests conferred with the elders,
the scribes and the entire Council. Then they tied up Jesus, took him
away, and handed him over to Pilate.[a] 2 Pilate questioned him: “You are
the king of the Jews?” “You say so,”[b] he answered. 3 The chief priests
kept bringing many charges against him. 4 So Pilate questioned him
once more: “Have you nothing to say in reply? Listen to how many
accusations they are making against you!” 5 But Jesus gave no further
answer at all, which left Pilate astonished.
6 At each festival Pilate used to set free for them one prisoner,
whomever they requested. 7 There was a man called Barabbas[c] held
in prison with the rebels who had committed murder during the
uprising. 8 So the crowd went up and started demanding that he follow
his usual practice for them. 9 Pilate replied, “Is it your wish that I set
free the king of the Jews for you?” 10 For he was aware that it was
out of envy that the chief priests had handed Jesus over. 11 The chief
priests, however, incited the crowd to ask that he free Barabbas for

them in place of Jesus. 12 Pilate spoke to them again: “Then what am
I to do with the one you call the king of the Jews?” 13 They shouted
back, “Crucify him!” 14 “Why? What crime has he committed?” Pilate
asked. But they only shouted louder, “Crucify him!” 15 Pilate, intent
on pleasing the crowd, released Barabbas to them; and he had Jesus
scourged[d] and then gave him up for crucifixion.
16 The soldiers marched him off inside the palace courtyard (the
governor’s residence)[e] and summoned the whole company of troops.[f]
17 They dressed him in purple, twisted together a crown of thorns, and
set it on his head. 18 Then they began to salute him: “Hail, king of the
Jews!” 19 They kept hitting him on the head with a reed and spitting on
him, and bending their knees, they paid him mock homage. 20 When
their mockery was over, they pulled the purple robe off him, dressed
him in his own garments, and took him out for crucifixion.
21 A passerby, Simon of Cyrene,[g] the father of Alexander and Rufus,[h]
was coming in from the country, and they forced him to carry Jesus’
cross. 22 They brought Jesus to the place called Golgotha, which
translated means “Place of a Skull.”[i] 23 They held out to him wine laced
with myrrh,[j] but he would not take it. 24 And they crucified him and
divided up his clothes, throwing dice for them to see what each would
take.[k] 25 It was nine o’clock in the morning[l] when they crucified him.
26 The notice of the charge against him was inscribed: THE KING OF
THE JEWS. 27 Two bandits[m] were crucified along with him, the one
at his right, the other at his left. 28 [n] 29 People going by hurled insults
at him, shaking their heads[o] and saying, “Ha! You who would tear
down the temple and rebuild it in three days, 30 save yourself and come
down from the cross!” 31 In the same way the chief priests, along with
the scribes, mocked him among themselves: “He saved others, but he
cannot save himself! 32 This Messiah, this king of Israel—let him climb
down from the cross this minute, so we can see it and believe!” Even
the men crucified beside him reviled him.
33 When noon came, darkness fell over the whole land[p] until three
in the afternoon.[q] 34 At three o’clock Jesus cried out in a loud voice,
“Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?”[r] which translated means, “My God,
my God, why have you forsaken me?” 35 Some of the bystanders who

heard it said, “Listen, he is calling Elijah.” 36 Someone ran and filled
a sponge with sour wine,[s] fixed it to a reed, and held it up for him
to drink, saying, “Leave him alone! Let us see if Elijah comes to take
him down.” 37 Then Jesus gave a great cry and breathed out his life. 38
And the curtain of the temple[t] was torn in two from top to bottom. 39
When the centurion[u] who stood facing him saw that he had died in
this way,[v] he said, “Truly this man was God’s Son!”[w]
40 Some women were also looking on from far away, among them
Mary Magdalene,[x] Mary the mother of James the younger and of
Joses, and Salome.[y] 41 While he was in Galilee they used to follow him
and provide for him; and many other women were there as well, who
had traveled up to Jerusalem with him.
42 It was already evening, and because it was Preparation Day—the
day before a Sabbath— 43 Joseph of Arimathea[z] came, a prominent
Council member who was also looking for God’s kingdom. He ven-
tured boldly into Pilate’s presence and requested Jesus’ body. 44 Pilate
was astonished that he had already died. He called the centurion and
asked whether Jesus had been dead for long.[aa] 45 Once the centurion
had confirmed it, Pilate gave Joseph the body. 46 Joseph bought a linen
cloth, took Jesus down, wrapped him in it, and laid him in a tomb that
had been cut into the rock. He then rolled a stone across the tomb’s
entrance. 47 Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Joses saw the
place where they put him.

Notes

- a (15:1) Pilate: Pontius Pilate, Roman prefect (governor) of Judea AD 26–36.
- b (15:2) You say so: an evasive or affirmative answer, meaning “That is your word for it” or “It is as you say.”
- c (15:7) Barabbas: Aramaic *bar Abba*, “son of the father.” Some manuscripts of Matthew (27:16–17) give his name as “Jesus Barabbas.”
- d (15:15) Scourged: Greek *phragellōsas*, from Latin *flagellum*, a scourge of leather thongs weighted with bone or metal, the brutal preliminary to crucifixion.
- e (15:16) Governor’s residence: Greek *praitōrion* (Latin *praetorium*), the official residence of the Roman governor in Jerusalem.
- f (15:16) Whole company of troops: literally “the whole cohort,” Greek *speira*, a unit of a Roman legion, nominally 600 soldiers, though the term was used of smaller detachments.

- g (15:21) Cyrene: a Greek city on the coast of North Africa (modern Libya), with a large Jewish community. *Simon* means "he has heard."
- h (15:21) Alexander and Rufus: *Alexander* is Greek, "defender of men"; *Rufus* is Latin, "red." They were apparently known to Mark's readers (compare Rom 16:13).
- i (15:22) Golgotha: Aramaic *gulgulta*, "skull." The Latin equivalent, *calvaria*, gives the traditional name "Calvary."
- j (15:23) Wine laced with myrrh: a drink perhaps meant to dull the pain (compare Prov 31:6).
- k (15:24) Ps 22:18. *Throwing dice*: literally "casting lots."
- l (15:25) Nine in the morning: literally "the third hour," counting from sunrise at about six o'clock.
- m (15:27) Bandits: or "rebels" (Greek *lēstai*), the term Josephus uses for insurgents.
- n (15:28) Verse 28 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and in the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Alexandrinus, Bezae and others). Many later manuscripts add, "And the scripture was fulfilled that says, 'He was counted among the lawless' " (Isa 53:12; compare Luke 22:37).
- o (15:29) Shaking their heads: compare Ps 22:7; 109:25; Lam 2:15.
- p (15:33) Land: or "earth." Compare Amos 8:9.
- q (15:33) Noon … three in the afternoon: literally "the sixth hour … the ninth hour."
- r (15:34) Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani: Ps 22:1, in Aramaic, transliterated in Greek. *Eloi* is Aramaic for "my God" (the Westcott–Hort reading here); some manuscripts have the Hebrew form *Eli* (compare Matt 27:46). *Three o'clock*: literally "the ninth hour." Westcott–Hort bracket the second "my God" in Mark's translation.
- s (15:36) Sour wine: Greek *oxos*, a cheap wine vinegar drunk by soldiers and laborers. Compare Ps 69:21.
- t (15:38) Curtain of the temple: probably the curtain separating the Most Holy Place from the Holy Place (Exod 26:31–33).
- u (15:39) Centurion: a Roman officer commanding about a hundred soldiers.
- v (15:39) Died in this way: literally "breathed out thus." Many manuscripts read "cried out and breathed his last in this way."
- w (15:39) God's Son: or "a son of God." The Greek lacks the article; the phrase may express a Roman soldier's recognition of a divine man or the full Christian confession (compare 1:1, 11; 9:7).
- x (15:40) Mary Magdalene: that is, Mary of Magdala, a town on the western shore of the lake; *Magdala* comes from Aramaic *migdal*, "tower."
- y (15:40) Salome: from Hebrew *shalom*, "peace." She may be the mother of James and John (compare Matt 27:56).
- z (15:43) Arimathea: probably Ramathaim (Ramah), the birthplace of Samuel (1 Sam 1:1), northwest of Jerusalem; the name means "heights." *Joseph* means "may he add" (Gen 30:24).

- aa (15:44) Had been dead for some time: Vaticanus, Bezae and some others, followed by Westcott–Hort in the margin, read “was already dead.”

Chapter 16

1 Once the Sabbath had ended, Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother
of James, and Salome purchased fragrant spices, intending to go and
anoint him. 2 Very early on the first day of the week, just after sunrise,
they made their way to the tomb. 3 They were saying to one another,
“Who is going to roll the stone back from the tomb’s entrance for us?”
4 But when they looked up, they saw that the stone—an exceedingly
large one—had already been rolled away. 5 Going into the tomb, they
saw a young man dressed in a white robe sitting on the right-hand
side, and they were struck with amazement. 6 “Do not be so amazed,”
he said to them. “You are looking for Jesus the Nazarene, the one
who was crucified. He has been raised; he is not here. See the spot
where they laid him. 7 Now go and tell his disciples, and Peter, ‘He is
going on ahead of you into Galilee. There you will see him, just as
he told you.’ ” 8 They came out and fled from the tomb, seized with
trembling and bewilderment; and they said nothing to anyone, for
they were afraid.[a]

9 [[After he rose early on the first day of the week, he appeared first
to Mary Magdalene, from whom he had driven out seven demons. 10
She went and told those who had been with him, as they mourned
and wept. 11 But when they heard that he was alive and that she had
seen him, they would not believe it.

12 After this he showed himself in another form to two of them as they
were walking along on their way into the country. 13 They went back
and told the others, but these did not believe them either.

14 Later he showed himself to the eleven themselves as they reclined
at table, and he rebuked them for their unbelief and stubbornness of
heart, because they had not believed those who had seen him after
he was raised.[b] 15 He said to them, “Go out into all the world and
announce the good news to the whole creation. 16 Whoever believes
and is baptized will be saved, but whoever refuses to believe will be
condemned. 17 Those who believe will be attended by these signs: they

will cast out demons by my name; they will speak in new tongues;[c]
18 they will pick up snakes [with their hands],[d] and if they drink any
deadly poison it will do them no harm; they will lay their hands on
the sick, and these will recover."
19 So then, after speaking with them, the Lord [Jesus] was taken up
into heaven and sat down at God's right hand.[e] 20 Then the disciples
set out and proclaimed the message far and wide, the Lord working
alongside them and confirming the word through the accompanying
signs.]][f]

Notes

- a (16:8) For they were afraid: here the earliest manuscripts, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, end the Gospel of Mark, as do the Sinaitic Syriac, about a hundred Armenian manuscripts, and the two oldest Georgian manuscripts; Eusebius and Jerome report that almost all Greek copies known to them ended here. Westcott–Hort print 16:9–20 and the shorter ending within double brackets as early additions, not part of Mark's original text. Whether Mark intended to end at 16:8, or a lost ending once followed, remains debated. See the note at 16:20 for the endings found in other manuscripts.
- b (16:14) Raised: Westcott–Hort bracket "from the dead."
- c (16:17) New tongues: Vaticanus lacks "new"; Westcott–Hort retain it.
- d (16:18) With their hands: Westcott–Hort bracket these words, which Alexandrinus and many others lack.
- e (16:19) God's right hand: compare Ps 110:1. *Jesus* is bracketed by Westcott–Hort.
- f (16:20) The endings of Mark. (1) The *longer ending* (16:9–20, printed here in double brackets) appears in Alexandrinus, Ephraemi, Bezae, Washingtonianus and the great majority of later manuscripts, and Irenaeus (late 2nd century) knew of it. Its vocabulary and style differ markedly from the rest of Mark, and it draws on the resurrection accounts of the other Gospels and Acts. (2) The *shorter ending*, which Westcott–Hort also print in double brackets, comes after 16:8 in a few manuscripts (alone in Codex Bobiensis and the Old Latin k; in several Greek manuscripts it is followed by the longer ending). In summary, it says the women briefly passed on their instructions to Peter's companions, and that afterward Jesus himself sent out through them, from east to west, the holy and unfading message of eternal salvation. [Amen.] (3) The *Freer Logion*, found only in Codex Washingtonianus (W, 4th–5th century) after 16:14, includes in part a reply from the disciples that this age of lawlessness and unbelief lies under Satan, who prevents God's truth and power from overcoming the unclean powers of the spirits, and so they ask Christ to reveal his righteousness at once. Christ answers that the span of years of Satan's authority is complete, but that other terrible things are near,

even for those sinners for whom he was handed over to death, so that they might turn to the truth, sin no more, and inherit the spiritual and imperishable glory of righteousness in heaven. Jerome mentions a form of this saying (*Against the Pelagians* 2.15). None of the early papyri of Mark (P45, P88, P137) preserves this chapter.

Luke

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Seeing that many have undertaken to set in order an account of the
events that have been brought to fulfillment among us, 2 in keeping
with what was handed down to us by the people who were eyewit-
nesses from the outset and who became servants of the message, 3 it
seemed right to me as well, after investigating everything carefully
from the beginning, to write an orderly account for you, most excel-
lent Theophilus,[a] 4 in order that you might come to recognize how
reliable are the matters in which you were instructed.[b]
5 In the time of Herod, king of Judea,[c] a certain priest by the name
of Zechariah belonged to the priestly division of Abijah.[d] His wife,
Elizabeth by name, was herself one of Aaron's descendants.[e] 6 Both
of them were upright before God, walking blamelessly in all the
commandments and requirements of the Lord.[f] 7 Yet they were child-
less, for Elizabeth could not conceive, and both of them were well
on in years. 8 It came about that, as he was carrying out his priestly
duties before God while his division was on duty, 9 according to the
custom of the priesthood, the lot fell to him to go into the sanctuary
of the Lord and burn incense.[g] 10 And all the throng of the people was
outside, praying at the time of the incense offering. 11 There appeared
to him an angel of the Lord, standing to the right of the incense altar.
12 Zechariah was shaken when he saw him, and fear fell upon him.
13 But the angel said to him, "Do not be afraid, Zechariah, for your
prayer has been answered. Your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son,
and you are to name him John.[h] 14 He will bring you joy and gladness,
and many will be happy because of his birth, 15 For in the Lord's sight
he will be great. Wine and strong drink he must never drink,[i] and he
will be full of the Holy Spirit while still in his mother's womb. 16 Many
of Israel's sons he will turn back to the Lord their God. 17 And he will

go ahead of him in Elijah's spirit and power, to turn fathers' hearts
toward their children,[j] and those who disobey toward the wisdom of
the just, to have a people ready and prepared for the Lord."
18 Zechariah said to the angel, "How shall I know this? For I am an
old man, and my wife is advanced in her days." 19 In reply the angel
said, "I am Gabriel.[k] I stand before God, and I have been sent to talk
with you and to announce this good news to you. 20 Look, you will be
silent, unable to say a word, until the day when these things happen,
since you did not trust my words, which will come true at their proper
time." 21 Meanwhile the people were waiting for Zechariah, and they
wondered why he was taking so long in the sanctuary. 22 On coming
out he was unable to speak to them, and they understood that he
had seen a vision in the sanctuary. He went on making signs to them
and stayed speechless. 23 When his days of service were completed,
he went back to his home.
24 Some time afterward Elizabeth his wife became pregnant, and for
five months she kept out of sight, saying, 25 "The Lord has done this
for me. In these days he has looked on me with favor, to remove my
shame before others."
26 In the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God to a town
of Galilee named Nazareth,[l] 27 to a virgin promised in marriage to a
man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's
name was Mary.[m] 28 He came in to where she was and said, "Greetings,
you who have been shown favor! The Lord is with you."[n] 29 But she
was deeply troubled at his words, and she kept wondering what sort
of greeting this might be. 30 Then the angel told her, "Mary, have no
fear; you have found grace in God's sight. 31 Listen: you will conceive
and bear a son, and Jesus is the name you are to give him.[o] 32 He will
be great and will be called the Son of the Most High, and the Lord
God will give him the throne of his ancestor David. 33 and over Jacob's
house he will reign for all ages; his kingdom will never come to an
end." 34 But Mary asked the angel, "How can this be, when I have no
relations with a man?" 35 In reply the angel told her, "The Holy Spirit
will come over you, and the Most High's power will cast its shadow
over you. That is why the child to be born will be called holy, Son of

God.[p] 36 And look, Elizabeth your relative has also conceived a son in
her old age, and this is the sixth month for her who was called barren.
37 For no word from God will be without power."[q] 38 Mary said, "Here
I am, the Lord's slave woman.[r] Let it happen to me as you have said."
And the angel departed from her.
39 In those days Mary set out and went in haste into the hill country,
to a town of Judah. 40 She went into Zechariah's house and gave Eliz-
abeth her greeting. 41 And as Elizabeth heard Mary greet her, the child
jumped in her womb, and Elizabeth became full of the Holy Spirit. 42
With a great cry she called out, "Among women you are blessed, and
blessed is the fruit your womb bears! 43 And how has this happened
to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me? 44 The moment
the sound of your greeting came to my ears, look, the child within me
jumped for joy. 45 Blessed is the woman who believed that the things
the Lord has told her would be fulfilled."
46 And Mary said,[s]
"My soul magnifies the Lord,
47 and my spirit has exulted in God my Savior,
48 because he has looked upon the lowliness of his slave woman.
For look, from now on all generations will call me blessed,
49 for great things have been done for me by the Mighty One,
and his name is holy.
50 His mercy is for generation after generation
to those who fear him.
51 He has worked might with his arm;
he has scattered those who are proud in the thinking of their
hearts.
52 He has pulled down the powerful from their thrones
and raised the humble high.
53 The hungry he has filled with good things,
and the rich he has sent away empty.
54 He has come to the help of Israel his servant,
remembering mercy,
55 as he spoke to our fathers,
to Abraham and to his offspring forever."[t]

56 Mary remained with her some three months, and then went back
home.
57 Elizabeth's time to deliver arrived, and she gave birth to a son. 58
When her neighbors and family heard how the Lord had magnified
his mercy toward her, they shared her joy. 59 On the eighth day
they came for the child's circumcision, and they wanted to call him
Zechariah, his father's name. 60 But his mother spoke up: "No; he is to
be called John." 61 They told her, "None of your kin bears this name." 62
Then they gestured to his father, asking what name he wished to give
him. 63 Asking for a tablet, he wrote the words, "John is his name."
And all of them marveled. 64 Instantly his mouth was opened, and his
tongue too, and he began speaking and praising God. 65 Fear came on
all who lived around them, and throughout the whole hill country of
Judea all these things were talked about. 66 Everyone who heard of
it kept it in mind and said, "What will this child be, then?" For the
Lord's hand was indeed with him.
67 Then Zechariah his father was filled with the Holy Spirit and
prophesied, saying,[u]
68 "Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel,
because he has visited his people and brought about their redemp-
tion.
69 He has raised up a horn of salvation[v] for us
in the house of David his servant,
70 as he spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets from of old:
71 salvation from our enemies
and from the hand of all who hate us,
72 to show mercy to our fathers
and to remember his holy covenant,
73 the oath that he swore to Abraham our father,
to grant us
74 that, rescued from the hand of our enemies,
we might serve him without fear,
75 in holiness and righteousness before him all our days.
76 And you, child, will be called a prophet of the Most High;
for you will walk ahead of the Lord to make his ways ready,[w]

77 to grant his people the knowledge of salvation
by the forgiving of their sins,
78 because of the tender mercy of our God,
by which the dawn from on high will visit us,[x]
79 to give light to those sitting in darkness and in death's shadow,
to direct our feet into the path of peace."
80 And the child kept growing and gaining strength in spirit, and he lived in the desert places until the day of his public appearance to Israel.

Notes

- a (1:3) Theophilus: a Greek name meaning "friend of God" or "loved by God." *Most excellent* was a title of respect used for persons of rank (compare Acts 23:26; 24:3; 26:25). He may have been Luke's patron.
- b (1:4) Taught: Greek *katēchēthēs*, "informed" or "instructed."
- c (1:5) Herod the Great, king of Judea under Roman authority from 37 to 4 BC. *Judea* here means the whole Jewish homeland.
- d (1:5) Zechariah … Abijah: *Zechariah* means "Yahweh remembers." The priests were divided into twenty-four divisions that served in the temple in turn; Abijah's was the eighth (1 Chr 24:10). *Abijah* means "Yahweh is my father."
- e (1:5) Elizabeth: Greek *Elisabet*, Hebrew *Elisheba* (Exod 6:23, the name of Aaron's wife), probably "my God is an oath." The meaning of *Aaron* is uncertain.
- f (1:6) The Lord: in Old Testament phrasing like this, *kyrios* stands for Yahweh, as throughout Luke 1–2 where it refers to God (for example 1:9, 11, 15, 16, 17, 25, 28, 38, 45, 46, 58, 66, 68, 76).
- g (1:9) Each morning and evening a priest burned incense on the golden altar in the holy place of the temple (Exod 30:7–8); a priest might receive this honor only once in his life.
- h (1:13) John: Greek *Iōannēs*, from Hebrew *Yohanan*, "Yahweh has been gracious."
- i (1:15) Compare Num 6:3; Judg 13:4; 1 Sam 1:11. *Strong drink* (Greek *sikera*) is fermented drink other than wine, such as beer.
- j (1:17) Mal 4:5–6 (3:23–24 in Hebrew). *Elijah* means "my God is Yahweh."
- k (1:19) Gabriel: "God is my mighty one" or "man of God" (compare Dan 8:16; 9:21).
- l (1:26) Nazareth: a small village in Galilee, not mentioned in the Old Testament; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- m (1:27) Joseph … Mary: *Joseph* means "may he add" (Gen 30:24). *Mary* (Greek *Mariam*) is the Hebrew name *Miriam*; its meaning is uncertain.
- n (1:28) Greetings: Greek *chaire*, literally "rejoice," the ordinary greeting. *Favored one* translates *kecharitōmenē*, "one who has been shown grace." Many

later manuscripts add “Blessed are you among women” (from 1:42); the earliest witnesses do not have it.

- o (1:31) Jesus: the Greek form of the Hebrew *Yeshua* (*Yehoshua*, Joshua), “Yahweh saves.”
- p (1:35) Or “the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God.” Some manuscripts add “of you” after “to be born.”
- q (1:37) Or “For nothing will be impossible with God.” Compare Gen 18:14.
- r (1:38) Slave woman: Greek *doulē*, the feminine of *doulos*, “slave” or “bond-servant” (also in 1:48).
- s (1:46) Mary’s song (traditionally called the *Magnificat*, from its first word in Latin) echoes Hannah’s song (1 Sam 2:1–10) and many psalms. A few Old Latin manuscripts and some early writers attribute the song to Elizabeth.
- t (1:55) Compare Gen 17:7; 22:17–18; Mic 7:20. *Abraham* is explained in Gen 17:5 as “father of a multitude.”
- u (1:67) Zechariah’s song is traditionally called the *Benedictus*, from its first word in Latin.
- v (1:69) Horn of salvation: the horn is a figure of strength (1 Sam 2:10; Ps 18:2; 132:17).
- w (1:76) Compare Isa 40:3; Mal 3:1. In the Hebrew text, the Lord is Yahweh.
- x (1:78) Will visit us: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus; many manuscripts read “has visited us.” *The dawn from on high* (Greek *anatolē*, “rising,” also used in the Greek Old Testament for the messianic “Branch,” Jer 23:5; Zech 3:8) may refer to the rising sun or star (compare Num 24:17; Mal 4:2).

Chapter 2

1 At that time an edict was issued by Caesar Augustus[a] for a registration of the entire inhabited world. 2 This was the first registration,
made when Quirinius was governing Syria.[b] 3 So all were on their way
to register, every one to his home town. 4 Joseph too went up out of
Galilee, out of Nazareth town, into Judea, to David’s city, which is
called Bethlehem,[c] since he belonged to David’s house and lineage,
5 to be registered with Mary, who was promised to him in marriage
and was pregnant. 6 While they were in Bethlehem, the time came for
her to deliver her child, 7 There she bore her son, her firstborn. She
swaddled him and put him to lie in a feeding trough, since the guest
room had no space for them.[d]
8 Nearby, in the open country, shepherds were spending the night
guarding their flocks.

9 An angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord
shone all around them, and they were overcome with fear.[e]
10 The angel said to them, “Have no fear. See, I am announcing to you
good news of a great joy, which is for the whole people.
11 For today, in the city of David, a Savior has been born for you, who
is the Messiah, the Lord.[f]
12 This is to be your sign: a newborn baby, swaddled and lying in a
feeding trough, is what you will find.”
13 And all at once there appeared with the angel a multitude of the
army of heaven, praising God and saying,
14 “Glory to God in the highest heavens,
and on earth peace among people of his good pleasure!”[g]
15 After the angels had left them and gone into heaven, the shepherds
said to each other, “Come, let us go over to Bethlehem and look at
what has taken place, this thing the Lord has told us of.” 16 They
went in haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the baby lying in the
feeding trough. 17 Having seen him, they reported the word that had
been spoken to them concerning this child. 18 And all who heard were
astonished at what the shepherds told them. 19 But Mary kept all these
things, pondering them in her heart. 20 Then the shepherds returned,
giving glory and praise to God for everything they had heard and
seen, all of it as they had been told.
21 When eight days had passed and it was time to circumcise him, he
was given the name Jesus, the name given by the angel before he was
conceived in the womb.
22 When the days of purification required by the law of Moses[h] had
passed, Joseph and Mary brought him to Jerusalem to present him to
the Lord 23 (as it is written in the law of the Lord, “Every male that
opens the womb shall be called holy to the Lord”),[i] 24 and to offer a
sacrifice according to what is said in the law of the Lord, “a pair of
turtledoves or two young pigeons.”[j]
25 Now there was a man in Jerusalem whose name was Simeon.[k] This
man was upright and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel,
and the Holy Spirit was upon him.

26 The Holy Spirit had disclosed to him that he would not see death
until he had seen the Lord's Messiah.[l]
27 Led by the Spirit, he came into the temple; and when the parents
brought in the child Jesus to do for him what was customary under
the law,
28 Simeon took him into his arms and blessed God, saying,
29 "Now, Master, you are letting your slave depart
in peace, according to your word,[m]
30 for my eyes have seen your salvation,
31 which you made ready before the face of all peoples,
32 a light for revelation to the nations
and for glory to your people Israel."[n]
33 His father and mother were marveling at what was said about him.
34 Simeon blessed them and said to Mary his mother, "Look, this child
is destined for the fall and the rising of many in Israel, and for a sign
that will be spoken against 35 (and a sword will pierce through your
own soul too), so that the thoughts of many hearts may be laid bare."
36 There was also a prophetess, Anna[o] the daughter of Phanuel,[p] of the
tribe of Asher.[q] She was far advanced in years. After her girlhood she
had lived with her husband seven years, 37 and after that was a widow
up to the age of eighty-four.[r] She never went away from the temple,
but served God night and day with fasting and prayer. 38 Coming up
at that very moment, she gave thanks to God and spoke of the child
to everyone who was looking for Jerusalem's redemption.
39 Once they had carried out all that the law of the Lord required, they
went back into Galilee, to Nazareth, their town. 40 The child grew and
became strong, filled with wisdom, and the grace of God was upon
him.
41 Each year his parents would go to Jerusalem for the Passover feast.
42 When he was twelve years old, they went up as the custom of the
festival required. 43 After the days were over, as they were returning,
the boy Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem, and his parents did not
know it. 44 Thinking he was in the traveling party, they went a day's
journey and then began searching for him among their relatives and
acquaintances. 45 Not finding him, they returned to Jerusalem to look

for him. 46 Three days later they found him in the temple, seated in the midst of the teachers, both listening to them and putting questions to them. 47 Everyone who heard him was amazed by his insight and by the answers he gave. 48 His parents were astonished to see him, and his mother said, "Child, why have you treated us so? Here your father and I have been anxiously seeking you." 49 "Why did you look for me?" he said to them. "Didn't you know I had to be in my Father's house?"[s] 50 But they did not understand the saying he spoke to them. 51 And he went down with them to Nazareth and was subject to them. His mother kept all these words in her heart.

52 And Jesus kept advancing in wisdom and in stature,[t] and in favor with God and people.

Notes

- a (2:1) Caesar Augustus: Octavian, the first Roman emperor (31 BC–AD 14). *Augustus*, "revered," was a title given him by the Roman Senate in 27 BC.
- b (2:2) Quirinius: Publius Sulpicius Quirinius, Roman legate of Syria from AD 6, when he conducted a census of Judea (compare Acts 5:37). How this registration relates to the reign of Herod (1:5) is a long-debated historical question; some render "this registration took place before Quirinius was governing Syria." Scholarly review recommended.
- c (2:4) Bethlehem: "house of bread," David's hometown (1 Sam 16:1; Mic 5:2).
- d (2:7) Guest room: Greek *katalyma*, a lodging place or guest room (used of the upper room in 22:11), not necessarily an inn. The *feeding trough* (traditionally "manger") suggests the part of the house or shelter where animals were kept.
- e (2:9) An angel of the Lord … the glory of the Lord: in Old Testament phrasing, the angel and glory of Yahweh.
- f (2:11) The Messiah, the Lord: Greek *christos kyrios*, "anointed Lord." A few witnesses read "the Lord's Messiah," as in 2:26.
- g (2:14) People of his good pleasure: so the Westcott–Hort text with the earliest manuscripts (Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, first hands, and Codex Bezae), which read *eudokias*, "of good pleasure," meaning people on whom God's favor rests. Most later manuscripts read *eudokia*, giving "peace on earth, good will toward people."
- h (2:22) The purification of a mother after childbirth (Lev 12:1–8) and the redemption of a firstborn son (Exod 13:2, 12–15; Num 18:15–16). *Moses* is explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out."
- i (2:23) Exod 13:2, 12. In the Hebrew text, the Lord is Yahweh; the phrase *the law of the Lord* likewise means the law of Yahweh (also 2:24, 39).
- j (2:24) Lev 12:8, the offering allowed to those who could not afford a lamb.
- k (2:25) Simeon: Hebrew *Shimon*, linked with "hear" (Gen 29:33).

- l (2:26) The Lord's Messiah: literally "the Lord's anointed," an Old Testament phrase for the king chosen by Yahweh (1 Sam 24:6; Ps 2:2).
- m (2:29) Simeon's song is traditionally called the *Nunc Dimittis*, from its first words in Latin. *Master* is Greek *despotēs*.
- n (2:32) Compare Isa 42:6; 49:6; 52:10.
- o (2:36) Anna: Hebrew *Hannah*, "grace" or "favor" (1 Sam 1:2).
- p (2:36) Phanuel: a form of *Penuel*, "face of God" (Gen 32:30–31).
- q (2:36) Asher: "happy" or "blessed" (Gen 30:13). The tribe belonged to the northern kingdom of Israel.
- r (2:37) Or "had been a widow for eighty-four years."
- s (2:49) Or "about my Father's affairs"; literally "in the things of my Father."
- t (2:52) Or "in age." Compare 1 Sam 2:26.

Chapter 3

1 It was the fifteenth year of the rule of Tiberius Caesar.[a] Pontius Pilate
was the governor of Judea;[b] Herod was the tetrarch of Galilee,[c] his
brother Philip the tetrarch of the region of Ituraea and Trachonitis,
and Lysanias the tetrarch of Abilene.[d]
2 during the high priesthood of Annas and Caiaphas,[e] the word of God
came to John the son of Zechariah in the wilderness.
3 And he came into the whole area around the Jordan, preaching a
baptism of repentance that leads to forgiveness of sins,
4 as the book of the sayings of Isaiah the prophet has it:[f]

"The voice of one who calls aloud in the desert:
'Make ready the road for the Lord;
straighten his paths.
5 Every ravine will be filled in,
every mountain and hill made low;
the winding ways will be straightened,
and the rough roads made level;
6 and all flesh shall see the salvation of God.'"[g]

7 John said to the crowds that came out to be baptized by him, "You
brood of snakes! Who told you that you could escape the wrath that
is coming? 8 Produce fruit that shows you have repented. And do not
start telling yourselves, 'Abraham is our father.' I tell you, God can
make children for Abraham out of these stones. 9 The ax is already at

the root of the trees, and every tree that fails to bear good fruit will be chopped down and thrown into the fire."
10 The crowds kept asking him, "What then should we do?" 11 He answered them, "Whoever has two tunics[h] should share with the one who has none, and whoever has food should do the same." 12 Tax collectors[i] also came to be baptized, and they said to him, "Teacher, what should we do?" 13 He answered them, "Exact nothing beyond the amount you are directed to collect." 14 Soldiers also kept asking him, "And we, what should we do?" He told them, "Do not take money from anyone by force or by false accusation, and be content with your pay."
15 The people were filled with expectation, and everyone wondered in their hearts whether John might be the Messiah. 16 John answered them all, "I baptize you with water; but one is coming who is mightier than I, the strap of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie. He will baptize you in the Holy Spirit and fire. 17 He holds his winnowing fork[j] in his hand, ready to clear his threshing floor and store the wheat in his barn; but the chaff he will burn with a fire that cannot be put out."
18 So with many other words of exhortation he proclaimed the good news to the people. 19 But Herod the tetrarch, who had been rebuked by him on account of Herodias, his brother's wife,[k] and on account of all the evil things Herod had done, 20 added this to them all: he shut John up in prison.
21 Now when all the people were baptized, and Jesus also had been baptized and was praying, heaven was opened, 22 and the Holy Spirit descended on him in a physical form, as a dove. And a voice spoke from heaven: "You are my Son, whom I love; you make me very glad."[l]
23 Jesus himself was about thirty years old when he began. He was the son, as was supposed, of Joseph, the son of Heli,[m] 24 the son of Matthat, the son of Levi, the son of Melchi, the son of Jannai, the son of Joseph, 25 the son of Mattathias, the son of Amos, the son of Nahum, the son of Esli, the son of Naggai, 26 the son of Maath, the son of Mattathias, the son of Semein, the son of Josech, the son of Joda, 27 the son of Joanan, the son of Rhesa, the son of Zerubbabel, the son of Shealtiel, the son of Neri, 28 the son of Melchi, the son of Addi, the

son of Cosam, the son of Elmadam, the son of Er, 29 the son of Jesus,[n] the son of Eliezer, the son of Jorim, the son of Matthat, the son of Levi, 30 the son of Simeon, the son of Judah, the son of Joseph, the son of Jonam, the son of Eliakim, 31 the son of Melea, the son of Menna, the son of Mattatha, the son of Nathan, the son of David, 32 the son of Jesse, the son of Obed,[o] the son of Boaz, the son of Sala, the son of Nahshon, 33 the son of Admin, the son of Arni,[p] the son of Hezron, the son of Perez, the son of Judah, 34 the son of Jacob, the son of Isaac, the son of Abraham, the son of Terah, the son of Nahor, 35 the son of Serug, the son of Reu, the son of Peleg, the son of Eber, the son of Shelah, 36 the son of Cainan,[q] the son of Arphaxad, the son of Shem, the son of Noah, the son of Lamech, 37 the son of Methuselah, the son of Enoch, the son of Jared, the son of Mahalaleel, the son of Cainan, 38 the son of Enosh, the son of Seth, the son of Adam, the son of God.[r]

Notes

- a (3:1) Tiberius Caesar: Roman emperor AD 14–37. His fifteenth year was probably AD 28–29, depending on how the years were reckoned.
- b (3:1) Pontius Pilate: Roman prefect of Judea AD 26–36.
- c (3:1) Herod Antipas, son of Herod the Great, ruler of Galilee and Perea from 4 BC to AD 39. A *tetrarch* ("ruler of a fourth") was a minor ruler under Roman authority.
- d (3:1) Philip, another son of Herod the Great, ruled the territories northeast of the Sea of Galilee. Lysanias ruled Abilene, northwest of Damascus; he is otherwise known from an inscription.
- e (3:2) Annas was high priest AD 6–15 and remained influential; Caiaphas, his son-in-law, was high priest AD 18–36 (John 18:13). *Caiaphas* is a family name of uncertain meaning.
- f (3:4) Isaiah: "Yahweh is salvation."
- g (3:6) Isa 40:3–5, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- h (3:11) Tunics: the *chitōn* was a garment worn next to the skin, under the outer cloak.
- i (3:12) Tax collectors: men who collected tolls and taxes for the Romans or for Herod, often despised as collaborators and extortioners.
- j (3:17) Winnowing shovel: a wooden fork or shovel used to toss threshed grain into the wind, which blew the chaff away.
- k (3:19) Herodias was the wife of Herod Antipas's half-brother (Mark 6:17 calls him Philip); Antipas married her after divorcing his first wife.

- l (3:22) Compare Ps 2:7; Isa 42:1. Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses read, from Ps 2:7, “You are my Son; today I have fathered you.”
- m (3:23) Luke’s genealogy runs from Jesus back to Adam and differs from Matthew’s (Matt 1:1–16) between David and Joseph. The difference has been explained in various ways (for example, as Mary’s line, or by levirate marriage); none is certain. The Old Testament names are given in their Old Testament forms where they can be identified.
- n (3:29) Jesus: here the name of an ancestor; it is the Greek form of *Joshua*.
- o (3:32) Obed: the Westcott–Hort text reads *Iōbēl*, with Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus; most manuscripts read *Iōbēd*, the Obed of Ruth 4:21–22. The same person is meant.
- p (3:33) Admin … Arni: so the Westcott–Hort text, with some early manuscripts; the names do not appear in the Old Testament list (Ruth 4:19; 1 Chr 2:9–10, “Ram”). Many manuscripts read “the son of Amminadab, the son of Aram” (compare Matt 1:3–4). The manuscripts vary widely here.
- q (3:36) Cainan: this name appears in the Greek Old Testament (Gen 11:12) but not in the Hebrew text.
- r (3:38) The son of God: Adam had no human father; compare Gen 1:26–27; 5:1–3. *Adam* means “human being” or “humankind.”

Chapter 4

1 Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led
by the Spirit in the wilderness 2 where for forty days he was put to
the test by the devil.[a] Through those days he ate nothing, and at their
end he felt hunger. 3 The devil said to him, “If you are the Son of God,
tell this stone to turn into bread.” 4 Jesus answered him, “It is written,
‘A person shall not live on bread alone.’”[b]
5 Then the devil led him up and showed him all the kingdoms of the
inhabited world in an instant of time. 6 “All this authority, and the
glory of these kingdoms, I will give to you,” the devil told him, “for it
has been given into my hands, and I give it to whomever I choose. 7 If
you, then, will bow down in worship before me, it will all be yours.”
8 Jesus answered him, “It is written, ‘You shall worship the Lord your
God and serve him alone.’”[c]
9 Then he brought him to Jerusalem and set him on the pinnacle[d] of
the temple and said to him, “If you are the Son of God, throw yourself
down from here,

10 for it is written,

'He will give his angels orders concerning you, to guard you closely,'

11 and,

'They will lift you up in their hands, lest you strike your foot on a stone.'"[e]

12 In answer Jesus told him, "It is said, 'Do not test the Lord your God.'"[f]

13 Having completed every kind of testing, the devil went away from him until a fitting time.

14 And Jesus went back into Galilee in the Spirit's power, and word of him spread throughout the whole countryside. 15 He taught in their synagogues, and everyone gave him praise.

16 He went to Nazareth, where he had grown up, and on the sabbath he entered the synagogue as he usually did and stood to read.

17 The scroll of the prophet Isaiah was handed to him. He unrolled the scroll and found the place where it was written,

18 "The Spirit of the Lord is upon me,
because he has anointed me
to bring good news to the poor.
He has sent me to proclaim release to captives
and recovery of sight to the blind,
to send away the crushed in freedom,
19 to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor."[g]

20 He rolled the scroll up, returned it to the attendant, and took his seat. Everyone in the synagogue kept looking at him.

21 He began by saying to them, "Today this scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing."

22 Everyone bore witness to him and wondered at the words of grace coming from his lips, and they kept saying, "Isn't this Joseph's son?"

23 He said to them, "No doubt you will quote me this proverb: 'Doctor, cure yourself!' What we heard had happened in Capernaum,[h] do here also in your own hometown."

24 And he said, "Amen, I tell you, no prophet is welcome in his own hometown.

25 Truly, I tell you, in the time of Elijah there were many widows in
Israel. The sky had been shut for three and a half years, and a terrible
famine had spread throughout the land.
26 Yet Elijah was sent to none of them, only to a widow in Zarephath,
in the region of Sidon.[i]
27 And there were many with leprosy[j] in Israel in the time of Elisha the
prophet, and none of them was cleansed except Naaman the Syrian."[k]
28 All in the synagogue, on hearing these things, were filled with fury.
29 They rose up and forced him out of the town and took him to the
edge of the hill their town stood on, intending to hurl him over.
30 But he passed through the middle of them and went on his way.
31 He went down to Capernaum, a town of Galilee, and he was
teaching them on the sabbath. 32 They were astounded at his teaching,
because his word had authority. 33 In the synagogue there was a man
who had the spirit of an unclean demon, and he cried out with a
loud voice, 34 "Ha![l] What have we to do with you, Jesus of Nazareth?
Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are: the Holy One of
God." 35 Jesus rebuked him, saying, "Be silent, and come out of him!"
When the demon had thrown him down in their midst, it came out of
him without doing him any harm. 36 Amazement came over them all,
and they kept saying to one another, "What is this word? For with
authority and power he gives orders to the unclean spirits, and they
come out!" 37 And news of him kept spreading into every place in the
surrounding region.
38 After leaving the synagogue, he went to Simon's home. Simon's
mother-in-law was suffering from a high fever, and they asked him
to help her. 39 He stood over her and rebuked the fever, and it left her.
At once she got up and began to serve them.
40 At sunset, everyone who had friends or relatives sick with different
kinds of illnesses brought them to him, and he placed his hands on
each of them and cured them. 41 Demons too were coming out of
many, crying, "You are the Son of God!" He rebuked them and did not
permit them to say anything, since they knew he was the Messiah.
42 At daybreak he left and went off to a lonely place. The crowds kept
seeking him, and reaching him, they tried to hold him back so that

he would not go away from them. 43 But he told them, "I have to announce the kingdom of God as good news to the other towns as well, for this is why I was sent." 44 And he kept on preaching in the synagogues of Judea.[m]

Notes

- a (4:2) Devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer," the Greek Old Testament's rendering of Hebrew *satan*, "adversary."
- b (4:4) Deut 8:3. Many later manuscripts add "but by every word of God."
- c (4:8) Deut 6:13. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord your God" is "Yahweh your God," as also in 4:12.
- d (4:9) Pinnacle: literally "little wing," probably a high corner of the temple courts.
- e (4:11) Ps 91:11–12.
- f (4:12) Deut 6:16.
- g (4:19) Isa 61:1–2, with a line from Isa 58:6 ("to send away the crushed in freedom"), in the wording of the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh (Hebrew "the Spirit of the Lord Yahweh"). The *year of the Lord's favor* recalls the year of release (Lev 25:10).
- h (4:23) Capernaum: "village of Nahum," on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee.
- i (4:26) 1 Kgs 17:1, 8–16; 18:1. Zarephath was a Phoenician town; the widow was a Gentile.
- j (4:27) Leprosy: the Greek word covered various skin diseases, not only Hansen's disease (Lev 13–14).
- k (4:27) 2 Kgs 5:1–14. *Elisha* means "God is salvation." *Naaman* means "pleasant."
- l (4:34) Ha: or "Leave us alone!" (Greek *ea*).
- m (4:44) Judea: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts; here it probably means the whole Jewish homeland. Many later manuscripts read "Galilee."

Chapter 5

1 Once, while the crowd was pressing in on him to hear the word of God, he was standing beside the lake of Gennesaret.[a] 2 He saw two boats drawn up at the lakeside; the fishermen had stepped out of them and were washing their nets. 3 He got into one of the boats, which was Simon's, and asked him to put out a little way from the land. Then he sat down and taught the crowds from the boat. 4 When he had stopped speaking, he said to Simon, "Put out into deep water, and let down your nets for a catch." 5 Simon answered, "Master, we worked

hard all through the night and caught nothing. But at your word I will
let down the nets." 6 When they had done so, they enclosed a great
number of fish, and their nets were beginning to tear. 7 They signaled
to their partners in the other boat to come and help them. They came
and filled both boats, so that they began to sink. 8 Seeing this, Simon
Peter fell down at Jesus' knees and said, "Leave me, Lord, for I am
a sinner!" 9 For astonishment had seized him and all who were with
him at the catch of fish they had taken, 10 and so also James and John,
the sons of Zebedee, who were Simon's partners. Jesus said to Simon,
"Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching people alive."[b] 11
When they had brought their boats to land, they left everything and
followed him.
12 Once when he was in one of the towns, a man appeared who was
full of leprosy. Seeing Jesus, he fell face down and pleaded with him,
"Lord, if you want to, you are able to cleanse me." 13 He stretched
out his hand and touched him, saying, "I am willing. Be made clean."
Immediately the leprosy left him. 14 Jesus ordered him to tell nobody.
"Instead," he said, "go and let the priest see you, and bring the offering
for your cleansing that Moses prescribed, as evidence for them."[c] 15 But
the report about him spread all the more, and great crowds gathered
to hear him and to be healed of their illnesses. 16 But he himself kept
slipping away into the wilderness to pray.
17 On one of those days he was teaching, and sitting nearby were
Pharisees[d] and teachers of the law who had come out of every village
in Galilee and Judea, and out of Jerusalem. And the power of the Lord
was present for him to heal.[e] 18 Some men then arrived carrying a
paralyzed man on a mat. They tried to get him inside and set him
down in front of Jesus. 19 Since the throng gave them no way of getting
him in, they went up on the housetop and let him down through the
tiles on his mat, right into the middle, before Jesus. 20 Seeing their
faith, he said, "Friend,[f] your sins have been forgiven you." 21 The
scribes[g] and Pharisees began to question among themselves: "Who is
this who talks like this, blaspheming? Who but God alone can forgive
sins?" 22 Jesus, perceiving their reasonings, answered them, "Why are
you reasoning this way in your hearts? 23 Which is easier, to say, 'Your

sins are forgiven you,' or to say, 'Get up and walk'? 24 But so you may
know that the Son of Man[h] has authority on earth to forgive sins" —
and here he spoke to the paralyzed man — "I say to you, stand up,
pick up your mat, and go home." 25 At once he got up in front of them,
picked up the mat he had lain on, and set off for home, giving glory to
God. 26 Astonishment seized them all, and they glorified God and were
filled with fear, saying, "We have seen extraordinary things today."
27 Afterward he went out and saw a tax collector named Levi[i] sitting
in his tax booth. "Follow me," he said to him. 28 And he left everything,
got up, and began to follow him. 29 Afterward Levi held a great recep-
tion for him at his home, and many tax collectors and others were at
the table with them. 30 The Pharisees and their scribes grumbled to his
disciples, "Why are you eating and drinking with tax collectors and
sinners?" 31 In reply Jesus told them, "People in good health have no
need of a doctor, but the sick do. 32 I have not come to call the upright
but sinners to repentance."
33 They said to him, "John's disciples fast often and offer prayers,
and so do those of the Pharisees, but yours eat and drink." 34 Jesus
answered them, "Can you force the wedding guests[j] to fast while the
groom is with them? 35 But days will come, and when the bridegroom
is taken away from them, then they will fast in those days." 36 He spoke
a parable to them as well: "Nobody rips a piece from a new coat to
patch an old coat. If he does, he will have torn the new one, and the
piece taken from the new one will not match the old. 37 And no one
puts new wine into old wineskins. Otherwise the new wine will burst
the skins; it will be spilled, and the skins will be ruined. 38 New wine
must be put into fresh wineskins. 39 [And nobody who has drunk old
wine wishes for new; he says, 'The old is good.'][k]

Notes

- a (5:1) Lake of Gennesaret: the Sea of Galilee, named after the plain of Gennesaret on its northwest shore.
- b (5:10) Catching people alive: Greek *zōgreō*, "take alive."
- c (5:14) Lev 14:1–32.
- d (5:17) Pharisees: a Jewish party devoted to strict observance of the law and the traditions of the elders. The name probably means "separated ones."

- e (5:17) The power of the Lord: here *kyrios* refers to God. Many later manuscripts read “to heal them.”
- f (5:20) Friend: literally “Man” (Greek *anthrōpe*), a form of address.
- g (5:21) Scribes: experts in the law of Moses, who taught and interpreted it.
- h (5:24) Son of Man: an Aramaic expression meaning “human being,” used by Jesus to refer to himself, probably with reference to Dan 7:13–14.
- i (5:27) Levi: “joined” or “attached” (Gen 29:34). Matt 9:9 calls him Matthew.
- j (5:34) Wedding guests: literally “sons of the bridal chamber.”
- k (5:39) Westcott and Hort placed this verse in single brackets as doubtful; it is absent from Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses but present in the earliest manuscripts, including P75 (as reported in the standard editions), Sinaiticus and Vaticanus. *Good*: so the Westcott–Hort text; many manuscripts read “better.”

Chapter 6

1 It happened on a sabbath[a] that he was making his way through fields
of grain, and his disciples were plucking the heads of grain, rubbing
them in their hands, and eating them. 2 Some Pharisees asked, “Why
do you do a thing not permitted on sabbath days?” 3 Jesus answered
them, “Have you not even read about what David did when he was
hungry, he and his companions, 4 how he entered God’s house and
took the loaves of the presentation, ate them, and gave some to his
companions, though no one may lawfully eat them except the priests
alone?”[b] 5 And he told them, “The Son of Man is lord of the sabbath.”
6 Another sabbath came, and he entered the synagogue and was
teaching. There was a man present with a withered right hand. 7
The scribes and the Pharisees were watching him closely to see if
he would heal on the sabbath, so as to find grounds to accuse him. 8
But he knew what they were thinking, and he told the man with the
withered hand, “Get up and stand here in the middle.” And he rose
and stood there. 9 Then Jesus said to them, “Let me ask you something:
on the sabbath is it lawful to do good, or to do harm; to save a life,
or to destroy it?” 10 Looking around at all of them, he told the man,
“Stretch out your hand.” He did, and his hand was made sound again.
11 But they were filled with senseless rage and began discussing with
each other what they might do to Jesus.
12 In those days he went out to the mountain to pray, and he spent
the whole night in prayer to God. 13 At daybreak he summoned his

disciples and selected twelve from among them, to whom he gave the
name apostles:[c] 14 Simon, whom he also named Peter,[d] and Andrew
his brother; James and John; Philip and Bartholomew; 15 Matthew and
Thomas;[e] James son of Alphaeus, and Simon, who was called the
Zealot;[f] 16 Judas son of James, and Judas Iscariot,[g] who turned traitor.
17 He descended with them and stopped on level ground. A large group
of his disciples was there, along with a great crowd of people from all
over Judea, from Jerusalem, and from the coast of Tyre and Sidon,[h] 18
who had come to hear him and to be healed of their diseases. People
troubled by unclean spirits were set free, 19 and everyone in the crowd
was trying to touch him, because power came out of him and healed
them all.
20 Lifting his eyes toward his disciples, he said:

"Blessed are you who are poor, for yours is the kingdom of God.
21 Blessed are you who hunger now, for you will be fed until you are
satisfied.

Blessed are you who weep now, for you will laugh.
22 Blessed are you when people hate you, when they cut you off and
heap insults on you and throw out your name as evil, on account of
the Son of Man.
23 On that day rejoice and leap for joy, for look, your reward in heaven
is great; it was in the same way that their fathers treated the prophets.
24 "But woe to you who are rich, for you are already receiving your
comfort in full.
25 Woe to you who are full now, for hunger will come to you.

Woe to you who laugh now, for you will mourn and weep.
26 Woe to you when all people speak well of you, for it was in the same
way that their fathers treated the false prophets.
27 "But I say to you, my hearers: Love your enemies; treat well those
who hate you; 28 bless those who curse you; pray for those who
mistreat you. 29 If someone strikes you on one cheek, offer the other
as well; and if someone takes your coat, do not withhold your shirt
either. 30 Give to everyone who asks of you, and from one who takes
what is yours, do not demand it back. 31 Just as you want people to
treat you, treat them in the same way. 32 "If you love those who love

you, what thanks is due to you? Even sinners love those who love them. 33 And if you do good to those who do good to you, what thanks is due to you? Even sinners do that. 34 And if you lend to those from whom you hope to get something back, what thanks is due to you? Even sinners lend to sinners, so as to get back as much again. 35 No, love your enemies, do good, and lend, despairing of no one.[i] Then your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High, for he is kind to the ungrateful and the wicked. 36 Be merciful, just as your Father is merciful.

37 "Do not judge, and you will by no means be judged. Do not condemn, and you will by no means be condemned. Release, and you will be released. 38 Give, and gifts will come to you: good measure, pressed down, shaken together, overflowing, they will pour into your lap.[j] The measure you measure with is the measure you will receive."

39 He also told them a parable: "Can a blind man guide a blind man? Will not both of them fall into a pit? 40 A disciple is not above the teacher, but everyone, when fully trained, will be like his teacher. 41 Why do you look at the speck in your brother's eye, but take no notice of the beam in your own eye? 42 How can you tell your brother, 'Brother, let me remove the speck from your eye,' when you do not notice the beam in your own? You hypocrite! Take the beam out of your own eye first, and then you will be able to see well enough to take the speck out of your brother's.

43 "A good tree does not bear rotten fruit, and a rotten tree does not bear good fruit. 44 Each tree is known by the fruit it bears. People do not pick figs off thorns, nor do they harvest grapes from a briar. 45 The good person brings out good from the good treasure of the heart, and the evil one brings out evil from the evil; for out of the overflow of the heart the mouth speaks.

46 "Why do you call me 'Lord, Lord,' but do not do what I tell you? 47 Everyone who comes to me and hears my words and does them — I will show you what he is like. 48 He is like a man building a house, who dug, going down deep, and laid a foundation on the rock. When a flood came, the river burst against that house and could not shake it, because it had been well built.[k] 49 But whoever hears and does not do

is like a man who put up a house on bare earth, with no foundation. The river burst against it, and at once it collapsed, and the ruin of that house was great."

Notes

- a (6:1) On a sabbath: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts. Many manuscripts read "on the second-first sabbath," an expression of uncertain meaning.
- b (6:4) The loaves of the presentation: the twelve loaves set out before Yahweh in the holy place each sabbath (Lev 24:5–9), traditionally "showbread." See 1 Sam 21:1–6. *David* probably means "beloved." Codex Bezae adds after 6:4 a saying about a man working on the sabbath.
- c (6:13) Apostles: Greek *apostoloi*, "those sent out," "messengers."
- d (6:14) Peter: Greek *Petros*, "rock" or "stone"; compare Aramaic *Kepha* (Cephas). *Simon* is a Greek name used for Hebrew *Shimon* (Simeon), linked with "hear." *Andrew* means "manly." *James* is Greek *Iakōbos*, that is, Jacob. *Philip* means "lover of horses." *Bartholomew* means "son of Talmai."
- e (6:15) Matthew: probably "gift of Yahweh." *Thomas* means "twin" in Aramaic.
- f (6:15) The Zealot: Greek *zēlōtēs*, "zealous one," perhaps for the law, or a member of the later anti-Roman party. *Alphaeus* is a name of uncertain meaning.
- g (6:16) Iscariot: probably "man of Kerioth," a town in Judea, though other explanations have been offered. *Judas* is the Greek form of *Judah*, explained in Gen 29:35 as "praise."
- h (6:17) In the Westcott–Hort edition the words that follow in 6:18 ("who had come to hear him … diseases") are numbered as part of verse 17; the standard English numbering is followed here. *Tyre* and *Sidon* were Phoenician cities on the coast north of Galilee; *Tyre* means "rock."
- i (6:35) Despairing of no one: Greek *mēden apelpizontes*, which may mean "expecting nothing in return." So the Westcott–Hort text; some manuscripts read *mēdena*, "despairing of no one," which this rendering follows in sense. Scholarly review recommended.
- j (6:38) Lap: Greek *kolpos*, the fold of a garment above the belt, used as a pocket.
- k (6:48) Because it had been well built: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts. Many manuscripts read "because it had been founded on the rock" (compare Matt 7:25).

Chapter 7

1 When he had completed all his sayings in the hearing of the people,
he went into Capernaum. 2 There was a centurion[a] there whose slave,
whom he valued greatly, was sick and close to death. 3 Hearing of
Jesus, he sent Jewish elders to him with the request that he come

and bring his slave safely through. 4 When they reached Jesus, they
pleaded with him earnestly, saying, "He deserves to have you do this
for him, 5 for he loves our nation, and he himself built our synagogue
for us." 6 Jesus went with them. He was not far from the house when
the centurion sent friends to say to him, "Lord, do not go to any
trouble, since I am not worthy to have you come under my roof. 7
That is why I did not consider myself worthy even to come to you.
Just say a word, and let my servant be healed. 8 I too am a man under
authority, with soldiers under my command. When I tell one, 'Go!'
he goes; when I tell another, 'Come!' he comes; and when I tell my
slave, 'Do this!' he does it." 9 When Jesus heard this, he was amazed.
Turning toward the crowd that followed him, he said, "I tell you, I
have not found such faith even in Israel." 10 The messengers went back
to the house and found the slave restored to health.
11 Soon afterward[b] he went to a town called Nain,[c] and his disciples and
a large crowd went with him. 12 As he drew near the gate of the town,
look, a dead man was being carried out, the only son of his mother,
and she was a widow. A sizable crowd from the town was with her.
13 Seeing her, the Lord was moved with compassion for her, and he
told her, "Do not weep." 14 He came up and touched the bier, and those
carrying it stood still. And he said, "Young man, I say to you, get up!"
15 The dead man sat up and started talking, and Jesus handed him back
to his mother. 16 Fear took hold of them all, and they glorified God,
saying, "A great prophet has arisen among us!" and, "God has visited
his people!" 17 And this word about him spread through all Judea and
all the surrounding region.
18 John's disciples brought him a report of all these things. So John
summoned two of his disciples 19 and sent them to the Lord with the
question, "Are you the coming one, or are we to wait for someone
else?" 20 Reaching him, the men said, "John the Baptist sent us to put
this to you: 'Are you the coming one, or are we to wait for someone
else?'" 21 In that hour he healed many of illnesses and torments and
evil spirits, and to many blind people he gave the gift of sight. 22 And
he answered them, "Go and report to John what you have seen and
heard: blind people see again, lame people walk, people with leprosy

are cleansed, and deaf people hear, dead people are raised, poor people have good news brought to them.[d] 23 And blessed is anyone who does not stumble over me."[e]

24 When John's messengers had gone, Jesus began to talk to the crowds about John: "What did you go out to the wilderness to see? A reed swaying in the wind? 25 Then what did you go out to see? A man clothed in fine soft garments? Look, those in splendid garments, living in luxury, are found in kings' courts. 26 What then did you go out to see? A prophet? Yes, I tell you, and more than a prophet. 27 This is the man of whom it stands written, 'See, I send my messenger before your face, and he will make your road ready ahead of you.'[f]

28 I tell you, of all born of women, none is greater than John; yet one who is least in the kingdom of God is greater than he." 29 (All the people who heard, even the tax collectors, acknowledged God's justice, having been baptized with John's baptism. 30 But the Pharisees and the lawyers set aside God's purpose for themselves, since they had not been baptized by him.)[g]

31 "To what, then, shall I liken the people of this generation? What do they resemble?

32 They resemble children who sit in the marketplace and call out to each other, saying,

'We piped for you, but you would not dance;
we wailed, but you would not weep.'

33 For John the Baptist has come neither eating bread nor drinking wine, and you say, 'He has a demon.'

34 The Son of Man has come eating and drinking, and you say, 'Look, a glutton and a drunkard, a friend of tax collectors and sinners!'

35 Yet wisdom is vindicated by all her children."

36 One of the Pharisees invited him to dinner, so he went to the Pharisee's house and took his place at the table. 37 And look, a woman of that town, a sinner, learned that he was at table in the Pharisee's house, and she brought an alabaster flask of perfumed oil,[h] 38 and standing behind him at his feet, weeping, she began to wet his feet with her tears, and she wiped them with the hair of her head, and kept kissing his feet and anointing them with the perfume. 39 Seeing

it, the Pharisee who had invited him said within himself, “Were this
man a prophet, he would recognize who and what kind of woman it
is that touches him, for she is a sinner.” 40 In response Jesus said to
him, “Simon, I have something to say to you.” “Teacher,” he replied,
“say it.” 41 “A moneylender had two debtors. One owed five hundred
days’ wages, the other fifty.[i] 42 Since neither had anything to pay
with, he freely forgave both. Which of the two, then, will love him
the more?” 43 Simon answered, “The one, I suppose, for whom he
canceled the larger debt.” And he told him, “You have judged rightly.”
44 Then, turning toward the woman, he said to Simon, “Do you see this
woman? I came into your house; you gave me no water for my feet,
but she has wet my feet with her tears and wiped them with her hair.
45 You did not kiss me, but she, ever since I came in, has not ceased
to kiss my feet. 46 You did not anoint my head with oil, but she has
anointed my feet with perfume. 47 Therefore I tell you, her many sins
have been forgiven, because she has shown great love.[j] But whoever
has been forgiven little shows little love.” 48 Then he said to her, “Your
sins have been forgiven.” 49 Those reclining at table with him began to
say among themselves, “Who is this, who even forgives sins?” 50 But
he said to the woman, “Your faith has saved you; go in peace.”

Notes

- a (7:2) Centurion: a Roman officer in command of about a hundred soldiers; here probably in the service of Herod Antipas.
- b (7:11) Soon afterward: or “On the next day,” according to many manuscripts.
- c (7:11) Nain: a village in southern Galilee; the name may mean “pleasant.”
- d (7:22) Compare Isa 26:19; 29:18–19; 35:5–6; 61:1.
- e (7:23) Stumble over me: or “take offense at me.”
- f (7:27) Mal 3:1; compare Exod 23:20. In the Hebrew of Malachi it is Yahweh who speaks.
- g (7:30) Verses 29–30 may be Luke’s comment rather than the words of Jesus.
- h (7:37) Alabaster flask: a sealed jar of soft stone used for costly perfume.
- i (7:41) Five hundred days’ wages … fifty: Greek “five hundred denarii … fifty.” A denarius was a Roman silver coin, the usual day’s pay for a laborer.
- j (7:47) For she loved much: or “as is shown by her great love”; her love is the evidence, not the cause, of her forgiveness (compare 7:42–43).

Chapter 8

1 Soon afterward he was journeying through one town and village
after another, preaching and announcing the good news of God's
kingdom. The Twelve were with him, 2 and certain women who
had been cured of evil spirits and infirmities: Mary, the one called
Magdalene,[a] out of whom seven demons had gone, 3 and Joanna,[b] wife
of Chuza, Herod's steward, and Susanna,[c] and many other women,
who were providing for them out of their own resources.
4 When a large crowd was gathering and people from town after town
were making their way to him, he spoke by way of a parable: 5 "A
sower went out to scatter seed. As he scattered it, some fell on the
path and was stepped on, and the birds of the sky devoured it. 6 Other
seed dropped onto the rock, and when it came up it dried out for lack
of moisture. 7 Other seed fell in among thorns, and the thorns came
up with it and choked it. 8 And other seed fell into the good soil and
came up and yielded fruit a hundredfold." As he said this, he called
out, "Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!"
9 His disciples began asking him what this parable might mean. 10 He
said, "To you it has been granted to know the secrets[d] of the kingdom
of God, but to the rest it comes in parables, so that 'seeing they may
not see, and hearing they may not understand.'[e] 11 "Now the parable
means this: the seed is God's word. 12 Those along the path are the
ones who hear; then the devil comes and carries off the word from
their hearts, lest they believe and be saved. 13 Those on the rock are
the ones who, on hearing, welcome the word with joy; but these have
no root. They believe for a while, and in a time of testing they fall
away. 14 As for the seed that landed among thorns, these are people
who hear, but as time goes by, worries, wealth and the pleasures of
life choke them, and they bear no ripe fruit. 15 But the seed in the fine
soil stands for people who, having heard the word, keep it fast in a
noble and good heart and bear fruit through endurance.
16 "Nobody, after lighting a lamp, hides it under a jar or sets it beneath
a bed; instead he sets it on a lampstand, so that those coming in may
see the light. 17 For there is nothing hidden that will not become plain,
nor anything secret that will not be known and come out into the

open. 18 Pay attention, then, to how you hear. More will be given to
anyone who has; and from anyone who lacks, even what he supposes
he has will be taken away."
19 His mother and his brothers came to see him, but they could not
reach him because of the crowd. 20 Someone reported to him, "Your
mother and brothers are outside and would like to see you." 21 But he
answered them, "My mother and my brothers are these: the people
who hear God's word and do it."
22 It happened one day that he boarded a boat with his disciples and
said to them, "Let us cross over to the far side of the lake." So they
set out. 23 As they sailed, he fell asleep. A windstorm swept down on
the lake, and they were taking on water and were in danger. 24 They
went and roused him, saying, "Master, Master, we are perishing!" He
woke and rebuked the wind and the surging water; they ceased, and
all was calm. 25 He said to them, "Where is your faith?" Frightened
and amazed, they said to one another, "Who then is this, that he
commands even the winds and the water, and they obey him?"
26 They sailed down to the region of the Gerasenes,[f] which lies across
from Galilee. 27 When he got out on shore, he was met by a demon-
possessed man from the town. For a long while this man had gone
without clothes, and instead of a house he made his home among the
tombs. 28 When he saw Jesus, he cried out, fell at his feet, and shouted,
"What do you want with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I beg
you, do not torture me!" 29 For Jesus had been ordering the unclean
spirit to come out of the man. Again and again it had taken hold of
him; they would guard him, binding him with chains and fetters, yet
he would snap the restraints and be driven off into the desert by the
demon. 30 Jesus asked him, "What is your name?" He said, "Legion,"[g]
because many demons had gone into him. 31 And they kept begging
him not to order them to depart into the abyss.[h] 32 A sizable herd of
pigs was feeding there on the hillside, and the demons begged him
to let them enter these, and he gave them leave. 33 The demons came
out of the man and went into the pigs, and the herd rushed down
the steep bank into the lake and was drowned. 34 When the herdsmen
saw what had happened, they fled and spread the news in the town

and in the countryside. 35 People went out to see what had happened.
They came to Jesus and found the man from whom the demons had
gone out sitting at Jesus' feet, clothed and in his right mind, and
they were afraid. 36 The eyewitnesses reported to them how the man
who had been possessed by demons was rescued. 37 Then the whole
population of the surrounding region of the Gerasenes asked him to
go away from them, for they were gripped by great fear. So he got
into the boat and went back. 38 The man from whom the demons had
gone out kept begging to be allowed to stay with him, but Jesus sent
him away, saying, 39 "Return to your house, and recount everything
God has done for you." And he went off, proclaiming throughout the
whole town all that Jesus had done for him.
40 When Jesus came back, the crowd gave him a welcome, since every-
one was expecting him. 41 Then a man named Jairus[i] came, who was
the leader of the synagogue. He threw himself down at Jesus' feet and
begged him to come to his house, 42 because his only daughter, about
twelve years old, was dying. As Jesus went, the crowds were pressing
in on him. 43 A woman was there who had suffered from bleeding
for twelve years and could not be healed by anyone.[j] 44 Coming up
behind him, she touched the fringe[k] of his cloak, and her flow of
blood stopped instantly. 45 "Who touched me?" Jesus asked. As they all
denied it, Peter said, "Master, the crowds are pressing around you and
jostling you."[l] 46 But Jesus said, "Someone touched me, for I perceived
that power had gone out from me." 47 The woman saw that she could
not stay hidden, so she came forward trembling and fell at his feet. In
front of everyone, she explained why she had touched him and how
she had been healed immediately. 48 He said to her, "Daughter, your
faith has made you well; go in peace."
49 While he was still speaking, someone arrived from the home of the
synagogue leader with this message: "Your daughter is dead. Do not
trouble the Teacher any longer." 50 But Jesus heard it and answered
him, "Have no fear. Only believe, and she will be made well." 51 When
he came to the house, he let no one go in with him except Peter and
John and James, and the child's father and mother. 52 Everyone was
weeping and beating their breasts for her. But he said, "Stop weeping;

she has not died but is asleep." 53 They laughed at him, knowing she
was dead. 54 But he took her by the hand and called out, "Child, get
up!" 55 Her spirit returned, and she rose at once, and he directed that
she be given something to eat. 56 Her parents were beside themselves,
but he ordered them not to tell anyone what had taken place.

Notes

- a (8:2) Magdalene: "of Magdala," a town on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee; the name means "tower."
- b (8:3) Joanna: a feminine form of *John*, "Yahweh has been gracious." *Chuza* is a name of uncertain meaning; a *steward* managed an estate or household.
- c (8:3) Susanna: "lily."
- d (8:10) Secrets: Greek *mystēria*, "mysteries," things once hidden and now revealed.
- e (8:10) Isa 6:9.
- f (8:26) Gerasenes: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus, P75, and others (also 8:37). Other manuscripts read "Gadarenes" or "Gergesenes." Gerasa and Gadara were towns of the Decapolis southeast of the Sea of Galilee.
- g (8:30) Legion: a Latin military term for a Roman unit of several thousand soldiers.
- h (8:31) Abyss: Greek *abyssos*, the bottomless deep, here the place where evil spirits are confined (compare Rev 9:1–2; 20:1–3).
- i (8:41) Jairus: Greek form of *Jair*, "he enlightens" or "he awakens" (Num 32:41).
- j (8:43) So the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and others. Many manuscripts add "though she had spent all she had on physicians."
- k (8:44) Fringe: Greek *kraspedon*, the edge or tassel of the garment (compare Num 15:38–39).
- l (8:45) Many manuscripts read "Peter and those with him said," and add at the end "and you say, 'Who touched me?'"

Chapter 9

1 Calling the Twelve together, he granted them power and authority
over every demon and for curing diseases, 2 and he sent them out to
herald God's kingdom and to heal. 3 He told them, "Carry nothing
for the road: no staff, no bag, no bread, no silver, and do not have
a second tunic. 4 Whatever house you go into, stay on there, and
from there move on. 5 Wherever people refuse to receive you, when
you leave that town shake the very dust from your feet as evidence
against them." 6 So they set out and traveled from village to village,
announcing the good news and healing people everywhere.

7 Now Herod the tetrarch heard of everything that was happening
and was perplexed, since it was said by some that John had risen from
among the dead, 8 some that Elijah had appeared, and others that one
of the prophets of old had risen. 9 Herod said, "John I beheaded. Then
who is this I keep hearing such things about?" And he was eager to
see him.
10 On their return the apostles gave him an account of what they had
done. Taking them with him, he went off by themselves to a town
named Bethsaida.[a] 11 But the crowds found out and followed him. He
welcomed them and talked to them of the kingdom of God, and he
cured those in need of healing. 12 As the day began to wane, the Twelve
approached and told him, "Dismiss the crowd, so that they can go into
the villages and farms round about to find lodging and get provisions,
for here we are in a desolate place." 13 But he said to them, "You give
them something to eat." They answered, "We have nothing more than
five loaves and two fish — unless perhaps we are to go and purchase
food for this whole people." 14 For there were about five thousand
men. He told his disciples, "Have them recline in groups of about fifty
each." 15 They did so and got everyone seated. 16 Taking the five loaves
and the two fish, he looked up to heaven, blessed them, broke them,
and kept giving them to the disciples to set before the crowd. 17 They
all ate their fill, and what they had left over was gathered up, twelve
baskets of pieces.
18 It happened once, as he was praying in solitude, that the disciples
were with him, and he put a question to them: "Whom do the crowds
declare me to be?" 19 They replied, "John the Baptist; but others say
Elijah, and others that one of the ancient prophets has risen." 20 He said
to them, "And you, whom do you declare me to be?" Peter replied,
"The Messiah of God." 21 He sternly ordered them to tell this to no one,
22 "The Son of Man must endure great suffering and be rejected by the
elders, chief priests and scribes. He must be killed and on the third
day be raised."
23 To all he said, "Anyone who wishes to come after me must disown
himself, take up his cross each day, and follow me. 24 Those who want
to save their life[b] will lose it, but those who lose their life because

of me will save it. 25 What does a person gain by winning the entire
world if he loses or forfeits himself? 26 For whoever is ashamed of me
and of my words, of him the Son of Man will be ashamed when he
comes in his glory and the glory of the Father and of the holy angels.
27 I tell you truly, some who are standing here will not taste death until
they see the kingdom of God."
28 About eight days after these sayings, he took Peter and John and
James with him and went up onto the mountain to pray. 29 While he
prayed, the look of his face became different, and his clothing flashed
white as lightning. 30 And look, two men were talking with him, Moses
and Elijah, 31 who appeared in glory and spoke of his departure,[c] which
he was about to fulfill in Jerusalem. 32 Peter and his companions were
weighed down with sleep, but they stayed awake and saw his glory
and the two men standing with him. 33 As the men were parting from
him, Peter said to Jesus, "Master, it is a fine thing that we are here.
We should put up three shelters, for you, for Moses, and for Elijah" —
not knowing what he was saying. 34 While he was saying these things,
a cloud came and overshadowed them, and they were frightened as
they entered the cloud. 35 A voice came from the cloud: "This is my
Son, my Chosen One;[d] listen to him!" 36 After the voice had spoken,
Jesus was found alone. They kept silent and in those days told nobody
anything of what they had seen.
37 The next day, when they had come down from the mountain, a large
crowd met him.
38 And look, from the crowd a man cried aloud, "Teacher, I implore
you, look on my son, for he is the only child I have.
39 A spirit takes hold of him, and all at once he cries out; it convulses
him till he foams, and it will hardly leave him, battering him as it goes.
40 I pleaded with your disciples to expel it, but they could not."
41 Jesus answered, "O unbelieving and perverse generation, how long
must I be with you and put up with you? Bring your son here."
42 Even as the boy was coming, the demon dashed him down and
threw him into a convulsion. But Jesus rebuked the unclean spirit,
healed the boy, and gave him back to his father.

43 And everyone was amazed at the greatness of God.

¶Everyone marveled at all that Jesus was doing, and he said to his disciples,

44 "Let these words sink into your ears: the Son of Man is about to be handed over into human hands."

45 They did not grasp what this saying meant; its meaning was concealed from them, so they were unable to perceive it, and they were afraid to ask him about it.

46 An argument started among them over who among them could be the greatest. 47 But Jesus, knowing the reasoning of their hearts, took a little child and stood it at his side, 48 and told them, "The person who receives this child on account of my name is receiving me; and the person who receives me is receiving him who sent me. It is the smallest among you all who is great."

49 John spoke up: "Master, we saw a man expelling demons by your name, and we kept trying to prevent him, since he does not follow along with us." 50 But Jesus told him, "Do not prevent him. Anyone who is not against you is on your side."

51 As the days for him to be taken up[e] were coming to completion, he set his face resolutely to go to Jerusalem. 52 He sent messengers ahead of him, and they went and entered a village of Samaritans[f] to make preparations for him; 53 but the people did not receive him, because his face was set toward Jerusalem. 54 When his disciples James and John saw this, they said, "Lord, shall we command fire to come down out of the sky and destroy them?"[g] 55 But he turned and rebuked them.[h] 56 And they went on to another village.

57 As they traveled along the road, someone said to him, "I will follow you wherever you go." 58 Jesus told him, "Foxes have dens and the birds of the sky have roosts, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head." 59 To another he said, "Follow me." But he replied, "Allow me first to go and bury my father." 60 Jesus told him, "Leave the dead to bury their own dead; but as for you, go and spread the news of the kingdom of God." 61 Yet another said, "I will follow you, Lord; but first let me bid farewell to my household." 62 Jesus said to him, "No

one who sets a hand to the plow and then looks back is suited for the kingdom of God."

Notes

- a (9:10) Bethsaida: "house of fishing," a town at the north end of the Sea of Galilee.
- b (9:24) Life: Greek *psychē*, "life" or "soul," also in the rest of the verse.
- c (9:31) Departure: Greek *exodos*, "exodus," here a reference to his death and what followed.
- d (9:35) My Chosen One: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P45, P75, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus (Greek *ho eklelegmenos*). Many manuscripts read "my Beloved," as in Matt 17:5 and Mark 9:7. Compare Isa 42:1.
- e (9:51) Taken up: Greek *analēmpsis*, here of his ascension, and perhaps his death, compare Acts 1:2.
- f (9:52) Samaritans: inhabitants of Samaria, between Galilee and Judea, who worshiped on Mount Gerizim and were at odds with the Jews (compare John 4:9).
- g (9:54) Many manuscripts add "as Elijah also did" (compare 2 Kgs 1:10–12).
- h (9:55) This is how the Westcott–Hort text reads, supported by the earliest manuscripts (including P45 and P75 as reported in the standard editions, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus). Many later manuscripts add the words, "and said, 'You do not know what spirit you share; the Son of Man did not come to destroy people's lives but to save them.'" Some have only the first part.

Chapter 10

1 Following these events the Lord designated seventy-two[a] more, and
he dispatched them in pairs ahead of himself to every town and
locality where he intended to go. 2 He told them, "The harvest is
plentiful, but the laborers are few. So ask the Lord of the harvest to
send out laborers into his harvest. 3 Be on your way. I am sending you
off as lambs into the midst of wolves. 4 Do not carry a money bag or
a pack or sandals, and stop to greet nobody on the way. 5 Whatever
house you enter, first say, 'Peace to this house!' 6 If a son of peace[b] is
there, your peace will rest on him; if not, it will come back to you.
7 Stay in that one house and eat and drink whatever they offer you,
since workers deserve their pay. Do not go from house to house. 8
Whenever you enter a town and they welcome you, eat what is put in
front of you; 9 heal the sick who are there, and tell them, 'The kingdom
of God has come close to you.' 10 But if you go into a town where they
refuse to receive you, go out into its open streets and declare, 11 'We
wipe off against you even the dust from your town that has stuck

to our feet. Nevertheless, be sure of this: God's kingdom has drawn near.' 12 I say to you, Sodom will fare more tolerably on that day than that town.

13 "Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida![c] For had the miracles performed among you been performed in Tyre and Sidon, long ago they would have sat in sackcloth and ashes and repented. 14 But at the judgment it will be more bearable for Tyre and Sidon than for you. 15 And you, Capernaum, will you be lifted up as far as heaven? You will be brought down as far as Hades![d] 16 "Whoever hears you hears me; whoever sets you aside sets me aside; and whoever sets me aside sets aside the one who sent me."

17 The seventy-two came back joyfully, saying, "Lord, even the demons submit to us in your name!" 18 He said to them, "I saw Satan[e] fall from heaven like lightning. 19 Look, I have given you authority to tread on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing at all will harm you. 20 Even so, do not rejoice in this, that the spirits submit to you; rejoice rather that your names have been recorded in heaven."

21 In that same hour he rejoiced in the Holy Spirit and said, "I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because you have hidden these things from the wise and intelligent and revealed them to little children. Yes, Father, for such was your good pleasure. 22 Everything has been entrusted to me by my Father. Nobody knows who the Son is but the Father, nor who the Father is but the Son, and whoever the Son wills to make him known to."

23 Then, turning to the disciples, he said privately, "Blessed are the eyes that see what you see. 24 I assure you, many a prophet and king longed to see the things you are seeing, yet did not see them, and to hear the things you are hearing, yet did not hear them."

25 Then an expert in the law stood up to test him. "Teacher," he said, "what must I do to inherit eternal life?" 26 He said to him, "What is written in the law? How do you read it?" 27 He answered, "You shall love the Lord your God out of your whole heart, and with your whole soul, and with your whole strength, and with your whole mind; and your neighbor as yourself."[f] 28 Jesus told him, "You have answered

correctly. Do this, and you will live." 29 But he, wishing to justify
himself, asked Jesus, "And who is my neighbor?" 30 Jesus took this up
and said, "A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho,[g] and he
fell among robbers, who stripped him, beat him, and went off, leaving
him half dead. 31 A priest happened to be traveling along that road.
He saw the man, but moved to the other side and passed by. 32 So too
a Levite,[h] when he came to the place and saw him, passed by on the
other side. 33 But a Samaritan who was traveling came upon him, and
when he saw him he was moved with compassion. 34 He went to him
and bandaged his wounds, pouring on oil and wine. Then he put him
on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him. 35
The next day he took out two days' wages[i] and handed them to the
innkeeper. 'Look after him,' he said, 'and anything further you spend,
I will pay you back on my return.' 36 Which of these three seems to
you to have become a neighbor to the man who had fallen into the
hands of the robbers?" 37 He said, "The one who showed him mercy."
Jesus told him, "Go, and you do the same."
38 As they went on their way, he entered a certain village, and a woman
named Martha[j] welcomed him into her house. 39 She had a sister
named Mary, who seated herself by the Lord's feet and was listening
to his word. 40 Martha, however, was pulled in many directions by all
the serving. She came over and said, "Lord, does it not matter to you
that my sister has abandoned me to do the serving by myself? Tell
her to lend me a hand." 41 The Lord answered her, "Martha, Martha,
you are anxious and troubled about many things; 42 only a few things
are necessary, really only one.[k] Mary has picked the better part, and
it will not be taken away from her."

Notes

- a (10:1) Seventy-two: so the Westcott–Hort text, which brackets "two" (also 10:17); the manuscripts are divided between "seventy-two" and "seventy." Compare the nations in Gen 10, numbered seventy in the Hebrew text and seventy-two in the Greek Old Testament.
- b (10:6) A son of peace: a Hebrew idiom for a person disposed to peace or worthy of it.
- c (10:13) Chorazin … Bethsaida: towns near the north shore of the Sea of Galilee. The meaning of *Chorazin* is uncertain.

- d (10:15) Hades: Greek *hadēs*, the realm of the dead, corresponding to Hebrew *Sheol*. Compare Isa 14:13–15.
- e (10:18) Satan: Hebrew for "adversary."
- f (10:27) Deut 6:5; Lev 19:18. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord your God" is "Yahweh your God."
- g (10:30) Jericho: a city near the Jordan, about 17 miles (27 km) from Jerusalem and some 3,300 feet (1,000 m) lower; the name may mean "moon city" or "fragrant."
- h (10:32) Levite: a member of the tribe of Levi who assisted the priests in the temple.
- i (10:35) Two days' wages: Greek "two denarii." A denarius was the usual day's pay for a laborer.
- j (10:38) Martha: Aramaic, "lady" or "mistress."
- k (10:42) Few things are needed, or only one: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and others. P45, P75, and many manuscripts read "one thing is needed"; some witnesses omit the words "you are anxious … only one."

Chapter 11

1 Jesus was praying somewhere, and when he finished, one of his disciples asked him, "Lord, teach us to pray, as John taught his disciples."
2 He told them, "Whenever you pray, say:
Father,[a] may your name be held holy;
may your kingdom come.
3 Day by day keep giving us our bread for the coming day;[b]
4 and pardon our sins,
since we also release all who owe us;
and bring us not into testing."[c]
5 He went on, "Imagine that one of you has a friend, and at midnight you call on him and say, 'My friend, lend me three loaves, 6 because a friend of mine has arrived at my place from a journey and I have nothing to set in front of him.' 7 And the man inside answers, 'Do not trouble me. The door has been shut by now, and my little ones are with me in bed. I am unable to get up and give you something.' 8 I tell you, though he will not get up and give him anything on the ground of friendship, yet because of his shameless persistence[d] he will rise and give him as much as he needs. 9 "And so I tell you: keep asking, and it will be given you; keep seeking, and you will find; keep knocking, and it will be opened for you. 10 For everyone who asks receives, the seeker finds, and to the one who knocks it will be

opened. 11 Which father among you, if his son asks for[e] a fish, will
hand him a snake in place of a fish? 12 Or if he asks for an egg, will
hand him a scorpion? 13 If you, who are evil, know how to give good
gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven
give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!"
14 He was driving out a demon that was mute. When the demon had
gone out, the mute man spoke, and the crowds were amazed. 15 But
some of them said, "It is by Beelzebul,[f] the ruler of the demons, that he
drives the demons out." 16 Others, putting him to the test, were seeking
a sign from heaven from him. 17 But he, knowing their thoughts, said
to them, "Any kingdom split against itself is laid waste, and house
falls upon house. 18 And if Satan too is split against himself, how
will his kingdom stand? For you claim that it is by Beelzebul I drive
out the demons. 19 If I drive out demons by Beelzebul, by whom do
your followers drive them out? For that reason, they will be your
judges. 20 If, however, I drive out the demons by God's finger,[g] then
God's kingdom has come upon you. 21 When a strong man, fully
armed, guards his own courtyard, his goods are undisturbed. 22 But
when someone stronger than he comes upon him and conquers him,
he strips him of the armor he trusted in and hands out the spoils. 23
Whoever is not on my side opposes me, and whoever does not join
me in gathering scatters.
24 "When the unclean spirit has gone out of a person, it roams through
waterless places seeking rest, and finding none, it says, 'I will go back
to my house that I left.' 25 On arrival it finds the house swept and put
in order. 26 Then it goes and brings along seven other spirits more
wicked than itself, and they go in and settle there; and that person's
final state turns out worse than the first."
27 While he was speaking these words, a woman lifted up her voice
from the crowd and told him, "Happy is the womb that bore you, and
the breasts that nursed you!" 28 But he replied, "No — happy instead
are the ones who hear the word of God and guard it!"
29 As the crowds were thronging together, he began to say, "This
generation is a wicked generation. It looks for a sign, yet no sign will
be granted it except the sign of Jonah.[h] 30 For as Jonah became a sign

to the Ninevites, so will the Son of Man be to this generation. 31 The queen of the South[i] will rise at the judgment with the men of this generation and condemn them, because she came from the ends of the earth to hear Solomon's wisdom; and look, something greater than Solomon is here. 32 At the judgment the men of Nineveh will rise up together with this generation and pass sentence on it, for they turned in repentance at Jonah's proclamation; and look, here is something greater than Jonah.

33 "No one lights a lamp and then hides it in a cellar or under a basket,[j] but sets it on a lampstand so that those who enter can see the light. 34 Your eye is the lamp of your body. When your eye is healthy,[k] your whole body is full of light; but when it is unhealthy, your body is full of darkness. 35 Watch out, therefore, that the light within you is not darkness. 36 If then your whole body is full of light, with no part of it dark, it will be wholly bright, as when a lamp shines on you with its gleam."

37 When he had spoken, a Pharisee invited him to have a meal at his house; so he went in and reclined at table. 38 The Pharisee was surprised to see that he did not first wash[l] before the meal. 39 But the Lord said to him, "Now you Pharisees cleanse the outside of the cup and the dish, but inside you are full of greed and wickedness. 40 Fools! Did not he who made the outside make the inside as well? 41 Rather, give as alms what is within, and look, everything is clean for you. 42 "But woe to you Pharisees! You tithe mint and rue and every garden herb, yet pass over justice and the love of God. These you ought to have practiced, without neglecting the others. 43 Woe to you Pharisees! You love the front seats in the synagogues and greetings in the marketplaces. 44 Woe to you! You resemble tombs that are not marked, which people walk on unawares."[m]

45 In response one of the lawyers said to him, "Teacher, by saying this you are insulting us as well." 46 He replied, "And woe to you lawyers! You weigh people down with loads that are crushing to carry, while you yourselves will not lay one finger on the loads. 47 Woe to you! You construct monuments for the prophets, whom your ancestors put to death. 48 Thus you testify that you approve of what your ancestors

did; they did the killing, and you do the building. 49 For this reason
also the Wisdom of God said, 'I will send them prophets and apostles,
and some of them they will kill and persecute,' 50 so that from this
generation may be required the blood of all the prophets, poured out
since the world was founded, 51 from Abel's blood to the blood of
Zechariah,[n] who met his death between the altar and the house. Yes,
I say to you, it will be required from this generation. 52 Woe to you
lawyers! You have carried off the key of knowledge. You yourselves
have not entered, and those who were entering you have blocked."
53 When he left there, the scribes and Pharisees began to oppose him
fiercely and to question him on many subjects, 54 lying in wait to catch
him in something he might say.

Notes

- a (11:2) Father: many manuscripts expand the prayer to resemble Matt 6:9–13, reading "Our Father in heaven" here, adding "may your will be done, on earth as in heaven" after "may your kingdom come," and adding "but rescue us from the evil one" (or "from evil") at the end of 11:4. The shorter form is that of the Westcott–Hort text, with P75, Vaticanus, and others.
- b (11:3) Bread for the coming day: Greek *epiousios*, a rare word of uncertain meaning; possibly "daily," "needed," or "for tomorrow."
- c (11:4) Testing: or "temptation."
- d (11:8) Shameless persistence: Greek *anaideia*, "shamelessness." It is uncertain whether the shamelessness is that of the asker or of the sleeper, who would be shamed by refusing.
- e (11:11) If his son asks for: many manuscripts add "bread, will give him a stone? Or if he asks for," as in Matt 7:9.
- f (11:15) Beelzebul: a name of uncertain meaning, perhaps "lord of the dwelling" or "lord of dung"; compare Baal-zebub, "lord of flies," in 2 Kgs 1:2.
- g (11:20) The finger of God: compare Exod 8:19.
- h (11:29) Jonah: Hebrew for "dove." Many manuscripts add "the prophet."
- i (11:31) The queen of the South: the queen of Sheba (1 Kgs 10:1–10).
- j (11:33) Basket: Greek *modios*, a container holding about 2 gallons (8.75 liters).
- k (11:34) Sound: Greek *haplous*, "single," "sincere," or "generous"; "bad" may also mean "stingy."
- l (11:38) Wash: Greek *baptizō*, here a ritual washing before meals.
- m (11:44) Contact with a grave made a person ritually unclean (Num 19:16).
- n (11:51) Zechariah: probably the priest stoned in the temple court (2 Chr 24:20–22), the last murder recorded in the Hebrew Bible, whose final book is Chronicles. The name means "Yahweh remembers."

Chapter 12

1 In the meantime, as the crowd assembled in tens of thousands,
until they were treading on one another, he started by addressing
his disciples: "Beware, above all, of the Pharisees' leaven, which is
hypocrisy. 2 Nothing is covered over that will not be uncovered, nor
secret that will not become known. 3 Therefore whatever you have
said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have
whispered into an ear in inner rooms will be proclaimed from the
housetops.
4 "To you, my friends, I say: have no fear of those who kill the body
and after that can do nothing further. 5 But I will show you whom to
fear: fear him who, once he has killed, holds the power to throw into
Gehenna.[a] Yes, I tell you, fear that one. 6 Five sparrows are sold for two
small coins,[b] are they not? And yet not one of them is forgotten in
God's sight. 7 Why, even the hairs of your head have all been counted.
Have no fear; you are worth more than a great many sparrows.
8 "I tell you, everyone who acknowledges me before people, the Son
of Man too will acknowledge before God's angels; 9 but whoever
disowns me in front of people will be disowned in front of God's
angels. 10 Everyone who utters a word against the Son of Man will
receive forgiveness; but for the one who has blasphemed the Holy
Spirit there will be no forgiveness. 11 When they bring you before
synagogues and rulers and authorities, do not worry about how to
defend yourselves or what to say; 12 For in that hour the Holy Spirit
will instruct you in the things you must say."
13 Someone in the crowd said to him, "Teacher, tell my brother to
divide the family inheritance with me." 14 But he told him, "Man, who
set me up as judge or arbitrator over the two of you?" 15 And he said to
them, "Look out, and guard yourselves against greed of every kind;
for even when someone has abundance, his life does not consist in
his possessions." 16 Then he told them this parable: "A rich man's land
produced an abundant harvest. 17 He reasoned with himself, 'What
shall I do? I have no room to store my produce.' 18 Then he said, 'Here
is what I will do: I will pull my barns down and build bigger ones, and
there I will gather in all my grain and my goods. 19 And I will say to

my soul, "Soul, you have plenty of goods [laid up for many years; take it easy, eat, drink,] enjoy yourself."'[c] 20 But God told him, 'Senseless man! On this night they are demanding your soul back from you. And all you have prepared — who will own it then?' 21 [So it is with anyone who lays up treasure for himself and is not rich toward God.]"[d]
22 Then he told his disciples, "For this reason I say to you, stop fretting over your life — what to eat — or over your body — what to wear. 23 Life is more than food, and the body more than clothing. 24 Think about the ravens: they do not plant or harvest, they have no storeroom or barn, yet God feeds them. How much more valuable you are than birds! 25 And which of you, by fretting, is able to add an hour[e] to the length of his life? 26 If then you cannot do even so small a thing, why be anxious about the rest? 27 Consider how the lilies grow: they neither toil nor spin. Yet I tell you, not even Solomon in all his splendor was robed like one of these. 28 If God clothes in this way the grass of the field, which is here today and is tossed into an oven tomorrow, how much more will he clothe you, you people of little faith! 29 So do not be searching for what to eat and what to drink, and do not hang in suspense. 30 For all the nations of the world chase after these things, and your Father knows you need them. 31 Instead, seek his kingdom,[f] and these things will be added to you. 32 "Do not be afraid, little flock, because it has pleased your Father to give you the kingdom. 33 Sell what you own and give to the poor. Provide yourselves with purses that will never wear out, a treasure in heaven that cannot fail, where no thief can reach it and no moth can destroy it. 34 For where your treasure is, there your heart will be as well.
35 "Keep your belts fastened[g] and your lamps lit, 36 Be like servants who are expecting their master on his way back from a marriage feast, ready to open for him the moment he arrives and knocks. 37 Blessed are those slaves whom the master finds awake when he comes. Truly I tell you, he will tie on an apron, have them recline at table, and come and wait on them. 38 Whether he comes before midnight or after it,[h] and finds them so, blessed are they. 39 Be sure of this: had the householder known the hour the thief would come, he would not

have allowed his house to be dug through.[i] 40 You also, be prepared,
since at an hour you do not imagine, the Son of Man comes."
41 Then Peter asked, "Lord, is it to us that you are speaking this
parable, or to all people too?" 42 The Lord answered, "Who, then, is the
trustworthy, prudent manager whom his lord will appoint over his
servants to hand out their portion of grain at the right time? 43 Blessed
is that slave whom his master on arrival finds doing so. 44 I tell you
truthfully, he will appoint him over everything he possesses. 45 But
suppose that servant tells himself, 'My master is taking a long time
to come,' and starts to beat the male and female servants, and to eat,
drink and get drunk, 46 the master of that servant will return on a day
when he is not expecting him and at a time he does not know. He will
cut him to pieces[j] and put him with the unfaithful. 47 And that slave
who was aware of what his master wanted yet made no preparation
and did not do as he wished will be flogged with many blows. 48 But
the one who did not know, and did things deserving a beating, will
be beaten lightly. Much will be required of everyone who has been
given much, and even more will be asked of the one who has been
trusted with much.
49 "I came to cast fire on the earth, and how I wish it were already
kindled! 50 I have a baptism to undergo, and how distressed I am until
it is accomplished! 51 Do you imagine I came to give peace on the
earth? Not at all, I tell you; rather, division! 52 For from this time on
there will be five in a single house split up, three against two and
two against three. 53 They will be divided, father against son and
son against father, mother against daughter and daughter against
mother, mother-in-law against her daughter-in-law and daughter-in-
law against her mother-in-law."[k]
54 He also said to the crowds, "When you see a cloud rising in the
west, at once you say, 'A rainstorm is coming,' and so it happens. 55
And when the wind blows from the south, you say, 'It is going to be
hot,' and it is. 56 Hypocrites! You know how to read the face of earth
and sky, but how is it you cannot read this present time? 57 "Why
not decide for yourselves what is just? 58 As you are going with your
opponent to the magistrate, make an effort on the way to settle with

him, so that he does not drag you to the judge, and the judge hand you over to the officer, and the officer throw you into prison. 59 I tell you, you will not get out of there until you have paid the very last cent."[l]

Notes

- a (12:5) Gehenna: the Valley of Hinnom south of Jerusalem, once a place of child sacrifice (Jer 7:31), used as a name for the place of final punishment.
- b (12:6) Two small coins: Greek "two *assaria*." An assarion was a Roman copper coin worth one sixteenth of a denarius (a day's wage).
- c (12:19) The words in brackets are bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; they are lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses but present in nearly all other manuscripts.
- d (12:21) The verse is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; it is lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses but present in nearly all other manuscripts.
- e (12:25) An hour: or "a cubit"; Greek *pēchys*, a forearm's length, about 18 inches (45 cm), here probably used figuratively of time.
- f (12:31) His kingdom: many manuscripts read "the kingdom of God."
- g (12:35) Keep your belts fastened: literally "Let your loins be girded," that is, with long robes tucked up for action.
- h (12:38) Before midnight or after it: literally "in the second or the third watch." The Romans divided the night into four watches: about 6–9 p.m., 9 p.m.–midnight, midnight–3 a.m., and 3–6 a.m.
- i (12:39) He would not have allowed: many manuscripts read "he would have stayed awake and would not have allowed."
- j (12:46) Cut him in pieces: or "punish him severely."
- k (12:53) Compare Mic 7:6.
- l (12:59) Cent: Greek *lepton*, the smallest copper coin, worth about one hundred twenty-eighth of a denarius (a day's wage).

Chapter 13

1 At that very time some people who were there brought him word about the Galileans whose blood Pilate had mingled with their sacrifices. 2 He responded, "Do you imagine that these Galileans, because they underwent such things, were greater sinners than every other Galilean? 3 By no means, I tell you. But unless you repent, you will every one of you perish as they did. 4 Or those eighteen on whom the tower at Siloam[a] fell and killed them — do you imagine they were more in debt[b] than all the other people living in Jerusalem? 5 By no means, I tell you. But unless you repent, you will all perish in the same way."

6 He went on to tell this parable: "A man had planted a fig tree in his
vineyard. He went to look for fruit on it and found none. 7 So he told
the gardener, 'Look, I have come for three years searching this fig
tree for fruit, and there is none. Cut it down! Why should it take up
space in the ground?' 8 He answered, 'Master, let it stand one more
year, until I dig around it and fertilize it. 9 If after this it yields fruit —
fine; but if not, you shall cut it down.'"
10 He was teaching in one of the synagogues on the sabbath. 11 There
was also a woman who for eighteen years had been disabled by a
spirit. She was bent over and could not stand up straight at all. 12 When
Jesus saw her, he called her over and told her, "Woman, you are set
free from your infirmity." 13 He laid his hands on her, and at once she
was made upright again and began to glorify God. 14 But the syna-
gogue ruler, angry because Jesus had done a healing on the sabbath,
said repeatedly to the people, "Six days there are for working. On
those, then, come and get your healing, not on the sabbath day." 15
The Lord answered him, "Hypocrites! Does not each of you on the
sabbath untie his ox or his donkey from the manger and lead it off
to water? 16 And this woman, a daughter of Abraham whom Satan
has kept tied up for eighteen long years — was it not right that she
be untied from this bond on the sabbath day?" 17 As he said these
things, all his opponents were put to shame, while the whole crowd
was delighted at all the glorious things being done by him.
18 So he said, "What is the kingdom of God like? To what shall I
compare it? 19 It is like a mustard seed that someone took and tossed
into his garden. It grew and turned into a tree, and the birds of the sky
nested in its branches." 20 Once more he said, "To what shall I compare
the kingdom of God? 21 It is like leaven that a woman took and hid in
about forty-five pounds of flour,[c] until the whole batch was leavened."
22 He journeyed on through towns and villages, teaching and making
his way toward Jerusalem. 23 Someone asked him, "Lord, is it only a
few who are being saved?" He said to them, 24 "Strain every nerve to
go in through the narrow door. For many, I tell you, will seek to go in
and will not manage it. 25 Once the owner of the house has risen and
locked the door, you will find yourselves standing outside, knocking

and pleading, ‘Lord, open the door for us!’ But he will answer, ‘I do not know where you are from.’ 26 Then you will say, ‘We ate and drank with you, and you taught in our streets.’ 27 And he will say, ‘I tell you, I do not know where you come from. Get away from me, all you doers of wrong!’[d] 28 There will be weeping there and grinding of teeth, when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets inside God’s kingdom, while you yourselves are being thrown outside. 29 People will come from east and west, and from north and south, and will recline at table in God’s kingdom. 30 And note this: there are last ones who will be first, and there are first ones who will be last.”
31 At that same hour some Pharisees came up and told him, “Leave this place and be on your way, for Herod intends to kill you.” 32 He replied, “Go and tell that fox, ‘Look, I drive out demons and carry out healings today and tomorrow, and the third day I am brought to completion.’ 33 Yet I must keep going today and tomorrow and the day after that, for it is unthinkable that a prophet should perish anywhere but in Jerusalem. 34 Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you! Time after time I wanted to gather your children as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you refused! 35 See, your house is abandoned to you.[e] And I tell you, you will not see me until you say, ‘Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord.’”[f]

Notes

- a (13:4) Siloam: Hebrew *Shiloah*, “sent,” a pool and district in the southeast of Jerusalem (compare John 9:7).
- b (13:4) In debt: that is, guilty; sin is often pictured as a debt (compare 11:4).
- c (13:21) About forty-five pounds of flour: Greek “three *sata* of wheat flour.” A saton (Hebrew *seah*) was about 13 liters, so the whole was about 10 gallons (39 liters), a very large batch of dough.
- d (13:27) Ps 6:8.
- e (13:35) Many manuscripts add “desolate.” Compare Jer 12:7; 22:5.
- f (13:35) Ps 118:26. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.

Chapter 14

1 It happened one sabbath, when he went to eat a meal in the house of one of the leading Pharisees, that they were watching him closely.
2 And look, before him stood a man suffering from dropsy.[a] 3 Jesus

responded by asking the lawyers and Pharisees, “Is healing on the
sabbath permitted, or not?” 4 But they held their peace. So he took
hold of the man, cured him, and let him go. 5 Then he asked them,
“Suppose your son[b] or your ox falls into a well on the sabbath. Will
you not pull him out right away?” 6 To this they had no reply to make.
7 Noticing how the guests were picking out the places of honor, he
told them a parable: 8 “Whenever someone invites you to a marriage
feast, do not recline in the foremost seat. A guest more eminent than
you may have been invited by him, 9 and the host who invited you
both comes and says to you, ‘Make room for this man,’ and then, red-
faced, you start to take the lowest place. 10 Instead, when someone
invites you, go and sit in the lowest seat, so that your host will come
and tell you, ‘My friend, move up higher.’ Then you will be honored
in front of all the other guests. 11 For all who exalt themselves will be
brought low, and those who humble themselves will be lifted up.”
12 He also said to his host, “When you put on a midday meal or an
evening meal, do not summon your friends, your brothers, your kin,
or wealthy neighbors; they might well invite you in return, and you
would be paid back. 13 Rather, when you give a reception, call the
poor, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. 14 Then you will be blessed,
because they have no means of repaying you; for you will be repaid
at the resurrection of the righteous.”
15 On hearing this, one of the dinner guests said to him, “Blessed is
whoever will eat bread in God’s kingdom!” 16 Jesus told him, “A certain
man was giving a great dinner and invited many. 17 At the dinner hour
he sent his slave to tell the invited guests, ‘Come, for everything is
now ready.’ 18 But one by one they all started to make excuses. The
first told him, ‘I have bought a field, and I need to go and inspect it.
Please excuse me.’ 19 Another said, ‘I have bought five yoke of oxen,
and I am on my way to try them out. Please, consider me excused.’ 20
Another said, ‘I have married a wife, and that is why I cannot come.’ 21
On his return the slave told his lord these things. At that the master of
the house was enraged and said to his slave, ‘Go out quickly into the
broad streets and alleys of the city and bring the poor, the maimed,
the blind, and the lame in here.’ 22 Then the slave said, ‘Sir, your order

has been carried out, and still there is room.' 23 So the master told the
slave, 'Go out to the roads and the hedgerows and compel people to
come in, so that my house may be filled. 24 I assure you, none of those
men who were invited shall so much as sample my banquet.'"
25 Large crowds were traveling with him, and he turned and said to
them, 26 "If anyone comes to me and does not hate[c] his own father
and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters — yes, and
even his own life — he cannot be my disciple. 27 Whoever does not
carry his own cross and come after me cannot be my disciple. 28 For
which of you, intending to build a tower, does not first sit down and
reckon up the cost, to see whether he has enough to complete it? 29
Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is unable to finish, all
the onlookers will begin to ridicule him, 30 saying, 'This fellow began
to build and was not able to finish.' 31 Or what king, setting out to meet
another king in battle, will not sit down first and deliberate whether
with ten thousand he is strong enough to face the one coming against
him with twenty thousand? 32 If he cannot, he sends envoys while the
other is yet far away and asks what the conditions of peace are. 33 In
the same way, then, none of you who does not say farewell to all his
possessions can be my disciple. 34 "Salt, then, is good; but if even salt
loses its taste,[d] with what will its saltiness be restored? 35 It is of no use
for the soil or for the manure heap; people throw it out. Let anyone
with ears to hear, hear!"

Notes

- a (14:2) Dropsy: Greek *hydrōpikos*, a disease in which fluid gathers in the tissues, causing swelling.
- b (14:5) A son: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P45, P75, Vaticanus, and many others. Some manuscripts read "a donkey" (compare 13:15), and a few "a sheep."
- c (14:26) Hate: a Semitic idiom for loving less or putting in second place (compare Matt 10:37; Gen 29:30–31).
- d (14:34) Loses its taste: Greek *mōrainō*, "becomes foolish" or "becomes insipid." The salt of the region, from the Dead Sea, contained impurities and could lose its savor.

Chapter 15

1 All the tax collectors and sinners were gathering around to listen to
him. 2 And both the Pharisees and the scribes kept grumbling, "This
man welcomes sinners and eats with them."
3 So he told them this parable: 4 "Suppose one of you has a hundred
sheep and loses one. Will you not leave the ninety-nine in the wilder-
ness and search for the lost sheep until you find it? 5 And having found
it, he lifts it onto his shoulders, rejoicing, 6 and on reaching home he
calls his friends and neighbors together. 'Celebrate with me,' he tells
them, 'for my lost sheep has been found.' 7 In the same way, I tell you,
there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than
over ninety-nine righteous persons who have no need of repentance.
8 "Or suppose a woman has ten silver coins[a] and loses one. Will she
not light a lamp, sweep the house, and search with care until she finds
it? 9 And having found it, she calls her women friends and neighbors
together, saying, 'Celebrate with me, for I have found the coin I lost.'
10 Just so, I tell you, joy arises before the angels of God over a single
sinner who repents."
11 He continued: "A certain man had two sons. 12 The younger one said
to his father, 'Father, give me my share of the estate.' So the father
divided his property between his two sons. 13 A few days later the
younger son turned everything into cash and went abroad to a distant
country, where he squandered his property in reckless living. 14 When
he had spent it all, a severe famine swept that country, and he began
to be in want. 15 He hired himself out to a citizen of that country,
who sent him to his fields to feed pigs. 16 He wished he could fill his
stomach[b] with the carob pods[c] that the pigs were eating, but nobody
gave him anything. 17 Coming to himself, he said, 'My father's hired
workers, all of them, have more bread than they need, while I am
perishing here from famine! 18 I will set off and go to my father, and I
will tell him, "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you. 19 I
no longer deserve to be called your son; treat me as one of your hired
men."' 20 So he got up and came to his own father. But while he was
still at a great distance, his father saw him and was moved to pity;
running to him, he fell on his neck and kissed him over and over. 21

The son said to him, ‘Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you; I no longer deserve to be called your son. [Treat me as one of your hired men.]’[d] 22 But the father told his slaves, ‘Quick! Bring out a robe, the finest, and put it on him; put a ring on his hand and sandals on his feet. 23 Fetch the fattened calf and slaughter it, and let us eat and celebrate; 24 for this my son was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found.’ And they began to celebrate.

25 “Meanwhile his elder son was out in the field. As he came near the house on his way in, he heard music and dancing. 26 He called one of the servant boys over and inquired what this might mean. 27 He told him, ‘Your brother has come home, and your father has slaughtered the fattened calf, because he has got him back safe and sound.’ 28 But he grew angry and would not go in. His father came out and kept pleading with him. 29 He answered his father, ‘Look! All these years I have been slaving for you, and never once disobeyed an order of yours; yet you never gave me so much as a young goat to celebrate with my friends. 30 But when this son of yours came, who has devoured your livelihood with prostitutes, for him you slaughtered the fattened calf!’ 31 He said to him, ‘My child, you are always with me, and all that is mine is yours. 32 But it was fitting to celebrate and be glad, for this brother of yours was dead and is alive; he was lost and is found.’”

Notes

- a (15:8) Silver coins: Greek *drachmai*. A drachma was a Greek silver coin worth about a day’s wage for a laborer.
- b (15:16) To fill his stomach: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and others; many manuscripts read “to fill his belly.”
- c (15:16) Carob pods: the pods of the carob tree, used as animal fodder and eaten by the very poor.
- d (15:21) The bracketed words are found in Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Codex Bezae, and a few others, but are lacking in P75 and most manuscripts; they may have been added from 15:19.

Chapter 16

1 Jesus also said to his disciples, “A rich man had a manager who was accused of wasting his master’s property. 2 So he summoned

the manager and asked, ‘What am I hearing about you? Turn in the account of your work, because you can no longer manage my affairs.’
3 The steward thought to himself, ‘What shall I do, since my lord is removing me from the stewardship? Digging I have no strength for; begging I would be ashamed of. 4 I know what I will do, so that when I am removed from the stewardship people will receive me into their homes.’ 5 Then he summoned his master’s debtors one by one. To the first he said, ‘What is the amount you owe my lord?’ 6 He said, ‘Six hundred gallons of olive oil.’[a] He told him, ‘Take your bill, sit down quickly, and write three hundred.’ 7 Then he asked another, ‘And you, how much do you owe?’ He said, ‘Six hundred twenty-five bushels of wheat.’[b] He told him, ‘Take your bill and write five hundred.’ 8 And the master commended the dishonest steward because he had acted shrewdly; for the sons of this age are shrewder in dealing with their own generation than the sons of light. 9 And I tell you, make friends for yourselves by means of the mammon[c] of unrighteousness, so that when it gives out they may receive you into the eternal dwellings. 10 “One who is trustworthy in a very little is trustworthy also in much, and one who is dishonest in a very little is dishonest also in much. 11 If, then, you have not proved trustworthy with unrighteous mammon, who will entrust you with what is genuine? 12 And if you have not been faithful with someone else’s property, who will hand over to you what belongs to you?[d] 13 No household slave can serve two masters. Either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will cling to one and scorn the other. You cannot be slaves to God and to mammon.”
14 The Pharisees, who were lovers of money, were listening to all this, and they sneered at him. 15 He said to them, “You are the ones who declare yourselves righteous in people’s eyes, but God knows your hearts; for what is lofty among humans is an abomination before God.
16 “The law and the prophets lasted until John. From then on the good news of God’s kingdom is being proclaimed, and everyone is forcing his way into it.[e] 17 Yet heaven and earth will sooner pass away than a single stroke[f] of the law fall to the ground. 18 “Any man who sends his wife away and marries another woman is committing adultery,

and anyone who marries a woman sent away by her husband is committing adultery.

19 "A certain man was rich, and he used to clothe himself in purple
and fine linen, enjoying a lavish feast every day. 20 Before his gateway
had been laid a poor man, Lazarus[g] by name, full of ulcers, 21 who
yearned to be fed with the scraps dropping from the rich man's table.[h]
The dogs even came and licked his ulcers. 22 In time the poor man
died and was carried away by the angels to Abraham's side.[i] The rich
man also died and was buried. 23 In Hades, in torment, he looked up
and saw Abraham far away with Lazarus beside him. 24 So he called
out, 'Father Abraham, have pity on me, and send Lazarus to dip the
tip of his finger in water and cool my tongue, for I am in anguish in
this flame.' 25 But Abraham replied, 'My child, remember: you in your
lifetime got your good things, and Lazarus in the same way got evil
things. Now here he is being consoled, while you are in anguish. 26
Besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has been fixed,
so that those who wish to cross from here to you cannot, nor may
anyone pass over from there to us.' 27 Then the rich man said, 'In that
case, father, I ask you to send him to the house of my father — 28 for I
have five brothers. Let him warn them, so that they will not end up in
this place of torment.' 29 But Abraham said, 'They have Moses and the
prophets; let them listen to them.' 30 'No, Father Abraham,' he replied,
'but if someone returns to them from the dead, they will repent.' 31 He
said to him, 'If they do not listen to Moses and the prophets, neither
will they be persuaded even if someone rises from the dead.'"

Notes

- a (16:6) Six hundred gallons of olive oil: Greek "a hundred *batoi* of oil." A batos (Hebrew *bath*) was about 22 liters (6 gallons), so the whole was about 2,200 liters. The reduction is by half.
- b (16:7) Six hundred twenty-five bushels of wheat: Greek "a hundred *koroi* of wheat." A koros (Hebrew *kor*) was about 220 liters (6¼ bushels), so the whole was about 22,000 liters. The reduction is by a fifth.
- c (16:9) Mammon: an Aramaic word for wealth or property, here almost personified (also in 16:11, 13).
- d (16:12) Your own: some manuscripts read "ours."

- e (16:16) Everyone is forcing his way into it: or “everyone is urged to enter it,” or “everyone is treating it violently”; the meaning of Greek *biazetai* is uncertain here.
- f (16:17) Stroke: Greek *keraia*, “little horn,” a small mark distinguishing one letter from another.
- g (16:20) Lazarus: a Greek form of *Eleazar*, “God has helped.”
- h (16:21) The scraps dropping: literally “the things falling”; many manuscripts read “the crumbs falling.”
- i (16:22) Abraham’s side: literally “Abraham’s bosom,” the place of honor beside the host at a banquet (compare John 13:23).

Chapter 17

1 He said to his disciples, “Snares that cause people to fall are bound
to come, but woe to the one through whom they come! 2 He would
be better off thrown into the sea with a millstone hung around his
neck than causing one of these little ones to stumble. 3 Keep watch
over yourselves. If your brother sins, reprove him, and if he repents,
forgive him. 4 Even if seven times in a day he sins against you, and
seven times turns back to you and says, ‘I repent,’ you must forgive
him.”
5 The apostles said to the Lord, “Increase our faith!” 6 The Lord replied,
“If you had faith like a grain of mustard seed, you could say to this
mulberry tree,[a] ‘Be uprooted and planted in the sea,’ and it would
obey you. 7 “Which of you who has a slave plowing or minding sheep
will say to him when he comes in from the field, ‘Come along at once
and take your place at table’? 8 Will he not rather tell him, ‘Get my
supper ready, put on your apron, and wait on me while I eat and
drink; afterward you can eat and drink yourself’? 9 Does he thank the
slave for carrying out his orders? 10 So it is with you as well. When
you have done all you were ordered, say, ‘We are slaves who deserve
no credit;[b] we have only done what was our duty.’”
11 On his way to Jerusalem, Jesus was traveling through the border
country[c] between Samaria and Galilee. 12 As he went into a certain
village, ten leprous[d] men met him. They kept their distance 13 and
raised their voices: “Jesus, Master, take pity on us!” 14 Seeing them,
he said, “Go, show yourselves to the priests.”[e] And as they went, they
were made clean. 15 One of them, seeing that he had been healed,

turned back, praising God at the top of his voice. 16 He fell face down at
Jesus' feet, thanking him; and he was a Samaritan. 17 Jesus responded,
"Were not ten made clean? Where are the other nine? 18 Did no one
come back to praise God except this foreigner?" 19 And he told him,
"Rise and go on your way; your faith has made you well."[f]
20 Once, on being asked by the Pharisees when the kingdom of God
would come, he answered them, "The kingdom of God does not come
in a way that can be watched for, 21 nor will people say, 'See, it is here!'
or 'There!' For look, the kingdom of God is within your grasp."[g]
22 Then he said to the disciples, "Days are coming when you will long
to see one of the days of the Son of Man, and you will not see it.
23 People will say to you, 'See, there!' or 'See, here!' Do not [go off,
or] chase after them.[h] 24 For just as lightning flashes and lights up the
sky from one end under heaven to the other, so will the Son of Man
be.[i] 25 Before that, however, he has many things to suffer and must be
rejected by this generation. 26 As things were in Noah's days, so they
will be also in the days of the Son of Man. 27 People ate, drank, married
and were given in marriage, up to the day Noah went into the ark;
then the flood came and destroyed every one of them. 28 It was the
same in the days of Lot: they ate, drank, bought, sold, planted, built; 29
but the day Lot went out from Sodom it rained fire and brimstone out
of the sky, and all of them perished. 30 It will be just like that on the
day the Son of Man is revealed. 31 On that day, anyone on the housetop
whose goods are in the house must not come down to fetch them;
likewise anyone in the field must not turn back for what is behind. 32
Remember Lot's wife![j] 33 Whoever seeks to keep his life safe will lose
it, but whoever loses it will preserve it alive. 34 I tell you, on that night
there will be two in one bed; one will be taken and the other left. 35
Two women will be grinding grain together; one will be taken and
the other left." 36 [k] 37 They asked him in reply, "Where, Lord?" He said
to them, "Where the body is, there the vultures[l] too will gather."

Notes

- a (17:6) Mulberry tree: Greek *sykaminos*, probably the black mulberry, a tree with deep and extensive roots.
- b (17:10) Who deserve no credit: or "unworthy," "useless"; Greek *achreioi*.

- c (17:11) Between: or “through the middle of”; the Greek phrase is unusual, and its precise sense is uncertain.
- d (17:12) Leprous: the Greek term for leprosy covered various skin diseases, not only Hansen’s disease.
- e (17:14) Compare Lev 14:1–32.
- f (17:19) Made you well: or “saved you.”
- g (17:21) Within your grasp: or “among you,” “in your midst,” or “within you”; Greek *entos hymōn*.
- h (17:23) Do not go off, or chase after them: the bracketed words are bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; the manuscripts vary in the wording here.
- i (17:24) So will the Son of Man be: many manuscripts add “in his day.” The words are lacking in P75, Vaticanus, Codex Bezae, and a few others.
- j (17:32) Compare Gen 19:26.
- k (17:36) Verse 36 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and in the earliest manuscripts, including P75, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Codex Bezae and some later witnesses add, “Two will be in the field; one will be taken and the other left” (from Matt 24:40).
- l (17:37) Vultures: or “eagles”; Greek *aetoi*.

Chapter 18

1 He told them a parable about their need to pray at all times and not lose heart. 2 “In a certain city,” he said, “there was a judge who had no
fear of God and no regard for any human being. 3 There was a widow
in that town who kept coming to him and saying, ‘Give me justice
against my opponent.’ 4 For a while he would not. But afterward he
said to himself, ‘Granted that I fear neither God nor any person, 5
still, because this widow keeps pestering me, I will see that she gets
justice, or else she will wear me out[a] with her endless coming.’” 6 And
the Lord said, “Listen to what the unjust judge says. 7 Will not God,
then, see justice done for his chosen ones who cry out to him day and
night? Will he be slow to help them?[b] 8 I tell you, he will see justice
done for them speedily. Yet when the Son of Man comes, will he find
faith on the earth?”
9 To certain people who were confident in themselves that they were
righteous, and who looked down on everyone else, he also told this
parable: 10 “Two men went up to the temple to pray, one a Pharisee
and the other a tax collector. 11 The Pharisee took his stand and prayed
thus about himself:[c] ‘God, I thank you that I am not like the rest of

humankind — swindlers, wrongdoers, adulterers — or even like this
tax collector. 12 Twice a week I fast; a tenth of all I acquire I give.’ 13
But the tax collector, standing far back, would not so much as raise
his eyes toward heaven, but kept striking his breast and saying, ‘God,
be merciful[d] to me, the sinner!’ 14 I tell you, it was this man, not the
other, who went down to his home justified. For everyone who raises
himself up will be humbled, while the one who humbles himself will
be raised up.”
15 People were bringing even their babies to him, for him to touch
them. When the disciples noticed, they scolded them. 16 But Jesus
summoned them, saying, “Allow the little children to come to me, and
stop preventing them; for God’s kingdom belongs to such as these. 17
Truly I tell you, whoever does not receive God’s kingdom as a little
child does will never enter it.”
18 A certain ruler put this question to him: “Good Teacher, what
must I do to inherit eternal life?” 19 Jesus said to him, “Why do
you call me good? No one is good but God alone. 20 You know the
commandments: ‘Never commit adultery or murder; never steal or
give false testimony; honor your father and mother.’”[e] 21 He replied,
“I have observed all these from my youth.” 22 On hearing this, Jesus
told him, “There is still one thing you lack. Sell everything you have
and distribute it to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven;
then come, follow me.” 23 But at these words he became very sad, for
he was extremely rich. 24 Looking at him, Jesus said, “How hard it is
for those who possess wealth to make their way into God’s kingdom!
25 It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for
a rich person to enter the kingdom of God.” 26 Those who heard it
said, “Then who can be saved?” 27 He replied, “Things impossible with
humans are possible with God.” 28 Peter said, “Look, we have left what
was ours and followed you.” 29 He told them, “Truly I tell you, there is
no one who has left house or wife or brothers or parents or children
for the sake of God’s kingdom 30 who will not receive many times as
much in this present time, and in the age to come eternal life.”
31 He took the Twelve aside and told them, “Listen, we are going up to
Jerusalem, and all that the prophets wrote about the Son of Man will

be fulfilled. 32 He will be delivered up to the nations; they will make
sport of him, treat him with contempt, and spit on him; 33 they will
scourge him and put him to death, and on the third day he will rise."
34 But they understood none of these things. This saying was hidden
from them, and they did not grasp what was being said.
35 When he was approaching Jericho, there was a blind man seated
beside the road, begging. 36 Hearing a crowd going by, he asked what
was happening. 37 They informed him, "Jesus the Nazarene[f] is going
past." 38 So he shouted, "Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!" 39
Those who were in front scolded him to make him be quiet, but he
cried out all the more, "Son of David, have mercy on me!" 40 Jesus
stopped and ordered the man brought to him. When he had come
near, Jesus asked him, 41 "What do you wish me to do for you?" He
answered, "Lord, I want to see again." 42 Jesus told him, "Receive your
sight! Your faith has healed you." 43 At once he could see, and he
followed Jesus, praising God. When all the people saw it, they too
praised God.

Notes

- a (18:5) Wear me out: Greek *hypōpiazō*, literally "give me a black eye," perhaps used figuratively.
- b (18:7) Will he be slow to help them: or "even though he is patient with them"; the sense of the clause is uncertain.
- c (18:11) About himself: or "to himself." Some manuscripts read "standing by himself, prayed thus."
- d (18:13) Be merciful: Greek *hilasthēti*, "be propitiated," "be reconciled."
- e (18:20) Exod 20:12–16; Deut 5:16–20.
- f (18:37) The Nazarene: Greek *ho Nazōraios*, "the Nazorean," probably meaning "from Nazareth."

Chapter 19

1 He entered Jericho and was making his way through it. 2 And there
was a man there, Zacchaeus[a] by name, who was a chief tax collector
and a wealthy one. 3 He kept trying to get a look at Jesus, to see
who he was, yet he was unable because of the throng, for he was a
small man. 4 So he ran on ahead and climbed up into a sycamore-
fig tree[b] in order to see him, since Jesus was about to come that
way. 5 When Jesus reached that spot, he looked up and called to him,

“Zacchaeus, hurry down, for I must stay at your house today.” 6 He
came down in haste and gladly welcomed him as his guest. 7 Everyone
who saw it began to grumble, “He has gone in to lodge with a sinful
man.” 8 But Zacchaeus stood and said to the Lord, “Look, Lord, I am
giving half of my possessions to the poor now, and anyone I have
defrauded of anything I will repay four times over.”[c] 9 Jesus said to
him, “Today salvation has come to this household, since he also is a
son of Abraham. 10 For the Son of Man came to look for the lost and
to save them.”
11 As they listened to these things, he added a parable, since he was
close to Jerusalem and they imagined that God’s kingdom was to be
revealed immediately. 12 So he said, “A man of noble birth traveled to
a far country to obtain royal power for himself and then return.[d] 13
Summoning ten of his slaves, he handed them ten sums of money,
each about a hundred days’ wages,[e] and told them, ‘Put this to work
in trade until I come.’ 14 But his citizens hated him, and they sent a
delegation after him to say, ‘We will not have this man reign over
us.’ 15 When he returned, having received the royal power, he had
those slaves to whom he had given the money called to him, to find
out what each had gained by trading. 16 The first came forward and
said, ‘Lord, your sum has earned ten sums more.’ 17 He told him, ‘Well
done, good slave! Since you proved faithful in a very small matter,
take charge of ten cities.’ 18 The second came and said, ‘Your sum, lord,
has made five sums.’ 19 He said to him likewise, ‘And you, be over five
cities.’ 20 Then the other one came and said, ‘Lord, here is your sum,
which I kept stored away in a cloth; 21 for I feared you, since you are
a hard man: you pick up what you never laid down and harvest what
you never planted.’ 22 He told him, ‘By your own words I will judge
you, you wicked slave! You knew, did you, that I am an exacting man,
collecting what I did not deposit and reaping what I did not sow?
23 Why then did you not put my money in the bank, so that on my
return I could have collected it with interest?’ 24 And to the bystanders
he said, ‘Take the sum from him and give it to the one who has the
ten.’ 25 They said to him, ‘Lord, he has ten already!’ 26 ‘I tell you, to
all who have, more shall be given; but from anyone who lacks, even

what he does have shall be taken away. 27 But those enemies of mine,
the ones unwilling for me to be king over them, bring them here and
execute them in my presence.'"
28 Having said these things, he went on ahead, going up to Jerusalem.
29 As he approached Bethphage and Bethany,[f] near the hill called the
Mount of Olives, he sent two of his disciples ahead,
30 saying, "Go into the village opposite. As you enter it you will find a
colt tied up that no one has ever yet sat on. Untie it and lead it here.
31 And if anyone asks you, 'Why are you untying it?' tell them, 'The
Lord needs it.'"
32 Those who had been sent went off and found things just as he had
told them.
33 As they were untying the colt, its owners said to them, "Why are
you untying the colt?"
34 They answered, "The Lord needs it."
35 They brought it to Jesus, threw their cloaks on the colt, and mounted
Jesus on it.
36 As he rode on, people kept spreading their cloaks on the road.
37 And as he was now approaching the descent from the Mount of
Olives, the whole throng of disciples began joyfully to praise God
with loud voices for all the mighty works they had seen,
38 saying,

"Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord![g]
In heaven peace, and glory in the highest!"

39 From among the crowd some Pharisees spoke to him: "Teacher,
rebuke your disciples."
40 He answered, "I tell you, if these keep quiet, the stones will shout
out."
41 As he came near and caught sight of the city, he wept over it, 42
saying, "If only you had recognized on this day, you of all people, the
things that make for peace! But as it is, they are hidden from your
eyes. 43 For days will come upon you when your enemies will throw
up a rampart against you, encircle you, and hem you in on every side.
44 They will dash you to the ground, you and your children within you,

and they will not leave one stone on another within you, because you did not recognize the time of your visitation."
45 He entered the temple and started driving out the merchants, 46 telling them, "It is written, 'My house shall be a house of prayer,'[h] but you have made it a bandits' cave." 47 Day after day he was teaching in the temple. The chief priests and the scribes were seeking to destroy him, and so were the leaders of the people; 48 yet they could find nothing they could do, for the whole people clung to him as they listened.

Notes

- a (19:2) Zacchaeus: from Hebrew *Zakkai*, "pure" or "innocent."
- b (19:4) Sycamore-fig tree: Greek *sykomorea*, a fig tree with low, spreading branches, not the North American sycamore.
- c (19:8) Four times over: compare Exod 22:1; 2 Sam 12:6.
- d (19:12) Compare the journey of Archelaus, son of Herod the Great, to Rome in 4 BC to be confirmed as king, and the Jewish delegation that opposed him (Josephus, *Antiquities* 17.299–314).
- e (19:13) Ten sums of money, each about a hundred days' wages: Greek "ten *minas*." A mina was a sum of a hundred drachmas, each drachma about a day's wage; so also "sum" in 19:16–25.
- f (19:29) Bethphage and Bethany: villages on the eastern slope of the Mount of Olives. *Bethphage* means "house of unripe figs"; the meaning of *Bethany* is uncertain, perhaps "house of affliction" or "house of Ananiah."
- g (19:38) Ps 118:26. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- h (19:46) Isa 56:7; compare Jer 7:11.

Chapter 20

1 One day, as Jesus was teaching the people in the temple and preaching the good news, the chief priests and scribes came up with the elders 2 and asked him, "Tell us what authority you have for doing these things. Who gave you this authority?" 3 In reply he said to them, "I too will put a question to you; tell me: 4 John's baptism — was it from heaven, or of human origin?" 5 They reasoned among themselves, saying, "If we answer, 'From heaven,' he will ask, 'Why did you not believe him?' 6 But if we answer, 'Of human origin,' the whole people will stone us, for they are convinced that John was a prophet." 7 Their answer was that they could not say where it was

from. 8 Jesus said to them, “Then I will not tell you what authority I
have for doing these things either.”
9 He began to tell the people this parable: “A man planted a vineyard,
leased it out to tenant farmers, and went abroad for a long time.
10 When the season came he dispatched a slave to the farmers, for
them to hand over to him some of the fruit of the vineyard; but the
farmers beat him and sent him away empty-handed.
11 He went on to send another slave; that one too they beat and treated
shamefully and sent off with nothing.
12 And he went on to send a third; this one too they wounded and
threw out.
13 Then the owner of the vineyard said, ‘What shall I do? I will send
my son, the beloved one; perhaps they will show him respect.’
14 But when the tenants saw him, they talked it over with one another:
‘This is the heir. Let us kill him, so the inheritance may become ours.’
15 So they threw him out of the vineyard and killed him. What, then,
will the owner of the vineyard do to them?
16 He will come and destroy these tenants and give the vineyard to
others.” When they heard this, they said, “May it never be!”
17 But he looked straight at them and said, “What then is this that is
written:

‘The stone that the builders rejected,
this has become the cornerstone’?[a]

18 Everyone who falls on that stone will be shattered, and anyone on
whom it falls, it will crush.”[b]
19 The scribes and chief priests wanted to arrest him then and there,
but they were afraid of the people, because they knew he had aimed
this parable at them. 20 Keeping him under watch, they sent agents
posing as honest men, to fasten on some word of his so they could
deliver him up to the rule and authority of the governor. 21 They
questioned him: “Teacher, we are aware that what you say and teach
is right, and that you do not favor anyone, but truly teach God’s way.
22 Does the Law permit us to pay taxes to Caesar, or not?” 23 But he saw
through their cunning and said to them, 24 “Show me a silver coin.[c]
Whose image and inscription does it bear?” They said, “Caesar’s.”

25 He told them, “Then render to Caesar the things that belong to
Caesar, and to God the things that belong to God.” 26 Before the people
they could not trap him in his words; amazed at his reply, they said
nothing more.
27 Some Sadducees, those who deny that there is a resurrection, came
to him and questioned him, 28 saying, “Teacher, Moses wrote for us
that if a man’s brother dies, leaving a wife but no child, the man
is to take the wife and raise up offspring for his brother.[d] 29 Now
there were seven brothers. The first took a wife and died childless;
30 then the second 31 and the third took her, and so on; all seven died
without leaving children. 32 Last of all the woman died too. 33 At the
resurrection, then, whose wife will the woman be, since all seven
were married to her?” 34 Jesus told them, “The children of this age
marry and are given in marriage; 35 but those who are judged worthy
to share in that age and in the resurrection from the dead will neither
marry nor be given in marriage. 36 Nor can they die anymore, for they
are like angels, and are sons of God, being sons of the resurrection.
37 And that the dead are raised Moses himself made known, in the
passage about the bush, where he calls the Lord ‘the God of Abraham
and the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob.’[e] 38 Now he is not God
of the dead but of the living; for to him all are alive.” 39 Some of the
scribes responded, “Teacher, you have spoken well.” 40 For they no
longer dared to question him on anything.
41 Then he put it to them: “In what sense is the Messiah said to be the
son of David?
42 For David himself says in the book of Psalms,
‘The Lord said to my Lord,
Sit at my right hand
43 until I set your enemies
as a footstool under your feet.’[f]
44 David then calls him ‘Lord’; so how is he his son?”
45 In the hearing of all the people he said to his disciples, 46 “Beware of
the scribes, who like to walk around in long robes and love greetings
in the marketplaces and the front seats in the synagogues and the
places of honor at banquets. 47 They devour widows’ houses, and for

show they make long prayers. These will receive the more severe judgment."

Notes

- a (20:17) Ps 118:22.
- b (20:18) Verse 18 echoes Isa 8:14–15 and Dan 2:34–35, 44–45.
- c (20:24) A silver coin: literally "a denarius," a Roman silver coin worth a day's wage, bearing the emperor's image and inscription.
- d (20:28) Deut 25:5–6; compare Gen 38:8.
- e (20:37) Exod 3:6. "The Lord" is Yahweh in the Hebrew of Exod 3:15–16.
- f (20:43) Ps 110:1. In the Hebrew, "The Lord said" is "Yahweh said"; "my Lord" is *adoni*, "my master."

Chapter 21

1 Looking up, he saw rich people dropping their gifts into the treasury.
2 And he noticed a certain needy widow dropping in two tiny copper
coins.[a] 3 And he said, "Truly I tell you, this poor widow has put in
more than all of them. 4 For these all contributed from what they had
left over, but she from her want has given her entire livelihood."
5 When some were remarking about the temple, how it was adorned
with fine stones and votive offerings, he said, 6 "As for these things
you are gazing at, days will come when not one stone here will be left
upon another that will not be torn down." 7 They asked him, "Teacher,
when, then, will these things be, and what will be the sign when
they are about to happen?" 8 He said, "Be careful not to be misled.
Many will come using my name and saying, 'I am he,' and, 'The
time is near.' Do not follow them. 9 And when you hear of wars and
upheavals, do not be terrified; for these things must take place first,
but the end does not follow at once." 10 Then he told them, "Nation
will fight against nation, and kingdom against kingdom. 11 There will
be powerful earthquakes, plagues and famines in various places, and
terrifying events and great signs from the sky. 12 But before all this
they will lay their hands on you and persecute you, handing you
over to synagogues and prisons, and you will be led before kings and
governors on account of my name. 13 It will turn out for you as an
opportunity for testimony. 14 So settle it in your hearts not to rehearse
your defense beforehand; 15 for I myself will give you a mouth and

wisdom that none of your opponents will be able to withstand or
contradict. 16 You will be betrayed even by parents and brothers and
relatives and friends, and some of you they will put to death. 17 You
will be hated by all because of my name. 18 Yet not a hair of your head
will perish. 19 By your endurance you will gain your lives.[b]
20 "When you see Jerusalem encircled by armies, then know that her
desolation has drawn near. 21 At that time let those who are in Judea
run for the hills, let those in the middle of the city leave it, and let
those out in the fields not enter it; 22 for these are days of vengeance, in
fulfillment of all that is written. 23 Alas for women who are pregnant
and for those nursing infants in those days! For there will be great
distress on the land and wrath against this people. 24 They will be
killed by the sword and taken captive among all nations, and Gentiles
will trample Jerusalem until the times of the Gentiles [are] complete.[c]
25 "There will be signs in sun and moon and stars, and on the earth
anguish among nations, bewildered by the roar of the sea and the
surging waves. 26 People will faint from fear and from foreboding
of what is coming upon the inhabited world, for the powers of the
heavens will be shaken. 27 And then they will see the Son of Man
coming in a cloud with power and great glory.[d] 28 When these things
begin to happen, stand up straight and lift your heads, because your
redemption is drawing near."
29 And he spoke a parable to them: "Consider the fig tree, and every
tree. 30 When they are already budding, you can tell by looking that
summer is at hand. 31 So also you, when you see these things taking
place, know that the kingdom of God is near. 32 Truly I tell you, this
generation will not pass away until all things take place. 33 Heaven
and earth will pass away, but my words will never pass away.
34 "Take heed to yourselves, lest your hearts be burdened by dissipa-
tion and drunkenness and the cares of daily living, and that day
spring upon you unexpectedly 35 like a snare. For it will come in upon
everyone living on the face of all the earth. 36 But stay awake at every
season, praying that you may have strength to escape all these things
that are going to happen, and to stand before the Son of Man."

37 Each day he was teaching in the temple, and each night he would
go out and spend the night on the hill called the Mount of Olives. 38
And early in the morning all the people would gather at the temple
to listen to him.[e]

Notes

- a (21:2) Tiny copper coins: Greek *lepta*, the smallest coins in use, each worth about one hundred twenty-eighth of a denarius (a day's wage).
- b (21:19) Gain your lives: Greek *psychē*, "soul" or "life." Many manuscripts read "you will gain" (future); others read "gain" (imperative).
- c (21:24) Are: the Westcott–Hort text brackets the words "and they will be" before "the times of the Gentiles," and they are lacking in many manuscripts.
- d (21:27) Compare Dan 7:13.
- e (21:38) After 21:38 a group of manuscripts (family 13) places the story of the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11).

Chapter 22

1 The feast of Unleavened Bread, which is called Passover, was draw-
ing near. 2 The chief priests and the scribes were looking for a way to
do away with him, for they were afraid of the people.
3 Then Satan entered into Judas, the one called Iscariot,[a] who was of
the number of the Twelve. 4 He went off and conferred with the chief
priests and officers of the temple guard about how he might betray
him to them. 5 They were delighted and agreed to give him money. 6
He agreed, and from then on he sought a favorable moment to deliver
him up to them apart from the crowd.
7 The day of Unleavened Bread arrived, the day on which the Passover
had to be slaughtered. 8 Jesus sent Peter and John, saying, "Go and
get the Passover ready for us to eat." 9 They asked him, "Where do
you want us to prepare it?" 10 He told them, "Listen: as you go into
the city, a man carrying a jar of water will meet you. Follow him into
the house he enters, 11 and tell the householder, 'Our Teacher wants
to know: Which room is set aside for me to eat the Passover meal
with my disciples?' 12 He will show you a large upstairs room, already
furnished. Make the preparations there." 13 Off they went, and they
found everything as he had said to them; and they made the Passover
ready.

14 When the hour arrived, he took his place at the table, and with him
the apostles. 15 He said to them, “With great longing I have longed to
eat this Passover with you before I suffer. 16 For I tell you that I will
never eat it until it finds its fulfillment in God’s kingdom.” 17 Then he
took a cup and gave thanks. “Take this,” he said, “and divide it among
yourselves. 18 For I tell you, from now on I will not drink of the fruit
of the vine until the kingdom of God comes.” 19 And he took bread,
gave thanks, broke it, and gave it to them, saying, “This is my body,
[[which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.” 20 Likewise
also the cup after supper, saying, “This cup is the new covenant in
my blood, which is poured out for you.]][b] 21 But look, the hand of the
one who will betray me is on the table with me. 22 The Son of Man
will go just as it has been decided, but how terrible for the man who
betrays him!” 23 And they began to debate among themselves which
of them it could be who was about to do this.
24 A quarrel broke out among them too, over which of them seemed
to be the greatest. 25 But he said to them, “The kings of the Gentiles
lord it over them, and those who exercise authority over them are
called benefactors. 26 Not so with you. Rather, let the greatest among
you become like the youngest, and the leader like one who serves. 27
For which is greater: the guest at the table, or the servant? Surely the
guest at the table. Yet here among you I am like a servant. 28 But it is
you who have remained with me through my trials. 29 So I assign to
you a kingdom, as my Father assigned one to me, 30 so that you may
eat and drink at my table in my kingdom, and you will sit on thrones
judging the twelve tribes of Israel.
31 “Simon, Simon, look: Satan has asked for you all,[c] so as to sift you
as wheat is sifted. 32 But I have prayed for you, that your faith will
not fail. And when you have turned back, strengthen your brothers.”
33 Peter said to him, “Lord, I am ready to go with you both to prison
and to death.” 34 But Jesus said, “I tell you, Peter, the rooster will not
crow today until you have three times denied that you know me.”
35 He said to them, “When I sent you out without purse or bag or
sandals, did you lack anything?” They said, “Nothing.” 36 He said to
them, “But now, whoever has a purse must take it, and likewise a bag;

and whoever has no sword must sell his cloak and buy one. 37 For I
say to you that what is written must find its completion in me: ‘And
with lawless men he was reckoned.’[d] For what concerns me is coming
to its end.” 38 They said, “Lord, look, here are two swords.” He said to
them, “It is enough.”
39 He went out and made his way, as was his custom, to the Mount of
Olives; and the disciples followed him. 40 When he reached the place,
he said to them, “Pray that you may not come into testing.”[e] 41 Then he
withdrew from them about a stone’s throw, knelt down, and prayed,
42 “Father, if it is your will, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, let
your will be done, not mine.” 43 [[Then an angel from heaven appeared
to him and strengthened him. 44 And being in anguish, he prayed
more earnestly, and his sweat became like great drops of blood falling
down on the ground.]][f] 45 When he rose from prayer and came to the
disciples, he found them sleeping for grief. 46 “Why are you asleep?”
he asked them. “Rise and pray, so that you do not enter into testing.”
47 While he was still speaking, a crowd appeared, and the man called
Judas, one of the Twelve, was leading them. He came near to Jesus to
kiss him. 48 But Jesus asked him, “Judas, would you betray the Son of
Man with a kiss?” 49 When those around him saw what was coming,
they said, “Lord, shall we strike with the sword?” 50 And one of them
struck the high priest’s slave and cut off his right ear. 51 But Jesus
answered, “Stop! No more of this!” And he touched the ear and healed
him. 52 Then Jesus said to those who had come out against him — chief
priests, officers of the temple guard, and elders — “Have you come
out with swords and clubs as if against a bandit? 53 Every day I was
with you in the temple, and you never laid a hand on me. But this is
your hour, when darkness has power.”
54 They seized him, led him away, and brought him into the high
priest’s house. Peter was following at a distance. 55 When they had
kindled a fire in the middle of the courtyard and sat down together,
Peter sat among them. 56 A servant girl noticed him sitting in the light
of the fire, looked at him closely and said, “This man was with him
too.” 57 But he disowned him: “Woman, I don’t know him.” 58 A little
later someone else saw him and said, “You also are one of them.”

But Peter said, “Man, I am not.” 59 About an hour later another kept
insisting, “Certainly this man also was with him, for he too is a
Galilean.” 60 But Peter answered, “Man, what you are saying I do not
know.” And immediately, before he had finished speaking, a rooster
crowed. 61 The Lord turned and looked at Peter, and Peter remembered
the word of the Lord, how he had said to him, “Before the rooster
crows today, you will deny me three times.” 62 [And he went outside
and wept bitterly.][g]
63 The men who were holding Jesus began mocking him as they beat
him. 64 They covered his face and questioned him: “Prophesy! Who
was it that hit you?” 65 And they said many other insulting things
against him.
66 At daybreak the elders of the people met together, chief priests as
well as scribes, and they brought him before their Sanhedrin,[h] saying,
67 “If you are the Messiah, tell us.” But he said to them, “If I tell you,
you will not believe, 68 and if I ask you, you will not answer. 69 But
from now on the Son of Man will be seated at the right hand of the
power of God.”[i] 70 All of them said, “Are you, then, the Son of God?”
He said to them, “You say that I am.” 71 Then they said, “What further
need of testimony do we have? We ourselves have heard it from his
own lips.”

Notes

- a (22:3) Iscariot: perhaps “man of Kerioth” (a town in Judea); the meaning is uncertain.
- b (22:20) Which is given for you … poured out for you: the Westcott–Hort text places these words in double brackets as one of the “Western non-interpolations,” since they are absent from Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses (some of which also reorder 22:17–19a). They are present in P75 (as reported in the critical editions), Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and nearly all other manuscripts, and modern critical editions (NA, SBLGNT) print them as part of the text.
- c (22:31) You all: the Greek pronoun is plural; in 22:32 “you” is singular, addressed to Simon.
- d (22:37) Isa 53:12.
- e (22:40) Testing: or “temptation”; so also in 22:46.
- f (22:44) The angel and the sweat like drops of blood (22:43–44) are placed in double brackets in the Westcott–Hort text. The verses are lacking in early and important witnesses, including P75 (as reported), Vaticanus, the first corrector of Sinaiticus,

and others, and some manuscripts mark them as doubtful; but they are present in the original hand of Sinaiticus, Codex Bezae, and many others, and were known to second-century writers. A few manuscripts (family 13) place them after Matt 26:39.

- g (22:62) The Westcott–Hort text places 22:62 in single brackets, since it is lacking in some Old Latin witnesses; it is present in almost all Greek manuscripts.
- h (22:66) Sanhedrin: the supreme Jewish council in Jerusalem, presided over by the high priest.
- i (22:69) Compare Ps 110:1; Dan 7:13.

Chapter 23

1 Then the whole assembly of them rose and brought him before
Pilate. 2 They began to accuse him, saying, "We found this man
subverting our nation, forbidding the payment of taxes to Caesar, and
claiming to be Messiah, a king." 3 Pilate questioned him: "Are you the
King of the Jews?" In answer he said to him, "You say so." 4 Pilate then
declared to the chief priests and the crowds, "I find no grounds for a
charge against this man." 5 But they pressed all the harder, saying, "He
stirs up the people with his teaching throughout all Judea; he began
in Galilee and has come even here."
6 On hearing this, Pilate inquired whether the man was a Galilean.
7 Learning that he belonged to Herod's jurisdiction, he referred him
to Herod, who was himself in Jerusalem during those days. 8 Herod
was overjoyed to see Jesus, for he had been wanting to see him for
a long while, because of what he had heard about him, and he was
hoping to watch some sign performed by him. 9 He questioned him
at length, but Jesus made him no reply. 10 Meanwhile the chief priests
and the scribes stood there, vehemently accusing him. 11 Herod and
his soldiers treated him with contempt and made a mockery of him;
then, dressing him in a splendid robe, he sent him back to Pilate. 12
That very day Herod and Pilate became friends with each other, for
before this they had been at enmity.
13 Pilate called together the chief priests, the rulers, and the people,
14 and said to them, "You brought me this man as one who leads the
people astray. Now look: I examined him in your presence and found
in him no basis for the charges you bring against him. 15 Nor did
Herod, since he has returned him to us. See, nothing worthy of death

has been done by him. 16 So I will have him flogged and let him go.”
17 [a] 18 But the whole crowd shouted together, “Take this man away!
Set Barabbas[b] free for us!” 19 He was someone who had been thrown
into prison for an uprising that had taken place in the city, and for
murder. 20 Pilate addressed them once more, wishing to release Jesus,
21 but they kept shouting back, “Crucify, crucify him!” 22 A third time
he spoke to them: “Why? What wrong has this man done? I have
found in him no cause deserving death. So I will have him flogged and
release him.” 23 But they kept pressing him with loud cries, demanding
that he be crucified, and their voices prevailed. 24 Pilate gave sentence
that what they asked should be done. 25 He set free the one whom they
requested, who had been put in prison for rebellion and murder; but
Jesus he delivered up to their will.
26 As they led him off, they grabbed a man named Simon from Cyrene,[c]
who was coming in from the countryside, and put the cross on him
to carry behind Jesus. 27 A large number of the people followed him,
among them women who were beating their breasts and wailing
for him. 28 But Jesus turned toward them and said, “Daughters of
Jerusalem, stop weeping over me. Weep over yourselves instead, and
over your children. 29 For look, days are coming when they will say,
‘Blessed are the barren, the wombs that never bore and the breasts
that never nursed.’ 30 At that time they will start saying to the moun-
tains, ‘Fall upon us!’ and to the hills, ‘Hide us!’[d] 31 For if they treat the
green tree like this, what will become of the dry?”
32 Two others also, who were criminals, were being led away with
him to be executed. 33 When they came to the place called the Skull,[e]
they crucified him there, and the criminals too, one on his right and
one on his left. 34 [[And Jesus was saying, “Father, forgive them, since
they do not understand what they are doing.”]][f] Then they cast lots
to share out his garments.[g] 35 The people stood watching, and the
rulers jeered at him: “He saved others; let him save himself if he is
the Messiah of God, the Chosen One!” 36 The soldiers joined in the
mockery, approaching him and holding out sour wine to him, 37 and
saying, “If you are the King of the Jews, save yourself!” 38 Above him
there was also a placard: “This is the King of the Jews.”

39 One of the criminals hanging there kept insulting him: "Are you
not the Messiah? Save yourself, and us!" 40 But the other rebuked
him, saying, "Have you no fear of God, since you are under the same
sentence? 41 And for us it is just, since we are receiving what is due for
what we did; but this one has done nothing improper." 42 Then he said,
"Jesus, remember me when you come into[h] your kingdom." 43 Jesus
said to him, "Truly I tell you, today you will be with me in paradise."
44 By now it was about noon, and darkness fell over all the land[i] until
three in the afternoon,[j] 45 the sun's light having failed;[k] and the curtain
of the temple was torn down the middle. 46 Then Jesus, crying out
with a loud voice, said, "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit."[l]
Having said this, he breathed his last. 47 The centurion, seeing what
took place, gave glory to God and said, "Surely this was a righteous
man." 48 And the crowds that had come together to view this sight,
once they had seen the things that happened, returned home striking
their breasts. 49 But all who knew him, and the women who had
accompanied him from Galilee, stood far off and saw these things.
50 Now there was a man named Joseph, a member of the council, a
good and righteous man, 51 He had not agreed to their plan and action.
He was from Arimathea, a Jewish town, and was looking forward to
the kingdom of God. 52 This man went to Pilate and asked for the body
of Jesus. 53 He took it down, wrapped it in a linen cloth, and laid him in
a tomb cut in the rock, where no one had ever yet been laid. 54 It was
the day of Preparation, and the sabbath was beginning to dawn.[m] 55
The women who had come with him from Galilee followed after, and
they saw the tomb and how his body was laid. 56 Then they went back
and prepared spices and ointments. And on the sabbath they rested
according to the commandment.[n]

Notes

- a (23:17) Verse 17 is lacking in the Westcott–Hort text and in the earliest manuscripts, including P75, Alexandrinus, and Vaticanus; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Many later manuscripts add, "For he had to release one man to them at the festival" (compare Matt 27:15; Mark 15:6), some of them after 23:19.
- b (23:18) Barabbas: Aramaic, "son of the father" or "son of Abba."

- c (23:26) Cyrene: a city in North Africa (in modern Libya) with a large Jewish community.
- d (23:30) Hos 10:8.
- e (23:33) The Skull: Latin *Calvaria*, from which comes “Calvary”; in Aramaic, *Golgotha*.
- f (23:34) The prayer “Father, forgive them…” is placed in double brackets in the Westcott–Hort text. It is lacking in early and diverse witnesses, including P75 (as reported), Vaticanus, the first hand of Codex Bezae, and some early versions; it is present in Sinaiticus (original and later hands), Alexandrinus, and most manuscripts. NA and SBLGNT print it within double brackets.
- g (23:34) Ps 22:18.
- h (23:42) Into: Greek *eis*. Many manuscripts read “in” (*en*) your kingdom, that is, “in your royal power.”
- i (23:44) Land: or “earth.”
- j (23:44) About noon … three in the afternoon: literally “about the sixth hour … until the ninth hour,” counted from sunrise.
- k (23:45) The sun’s light having failed: Greek *tou hēliou ekleipontos*, the reading of the Westcott–Hort text (with P75, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus); the verb can be used of an eclipse. Many manuscripts read “and the sun was darkened.”
- l (23:46) Ps 31:5.
- m (23:54) Beginning to dawn: Greek *epiphōskō*, used here of the start of the sabbath at sunset on Friday.
- n (23:56) Exod 20:10; Deut 5:14.

Chapter 24

1 On the first day of the week, at early dawn, they came to the tomb
bringing the spices they had prepared. 2 They found the stone rolled
away from the tomb, 3 yet on going inside they found no body [[of
the Lord Jesus]].[a] 4 And as they stood perplexed over this, look, two
men stood by them in clothing that flashed like lightning. 5 Filled with
fear, the women bent their faces toward the earth; and the men asked
them, “Why do you seek the living one among the dead? 6 [[He is
not here, but has been raised.]][b] Recall how he spoke to you while he
was still in Galilee, 7 saying that the Son of Man must be handed over
into the hands of sinful people, be crucified, and on the third day rise
again.” 8 Then they remembered his words, 9 and returning [from the
tomb][c] they reported all these things to the Eleven and to all the rest.
10 It was Mary Magdalene,[d] Joanna, Mary the mother of James, and
the other women with them who told these things to the apostles. 11

But these words seemed to them like nonsense, and they would not
believe the women. 12 [[But Peter got up and ran to the tomb; stooping
to look in, he saw the linen wrappings lying by themselves; and he
went home, wondering at what had happened.]][e]
13 And look, on that very day two of them were traveling to a village
about seven miles[f] away from Jerusalem, whose name was Emmaus, 14
and they were conversing with each other about all these events. 15 As
they talked and debated, Jesus himself drew near and began walking
along with them, 16 but their eyes were kept from recognizing him.
17 He said to them, "What are these words you are exchanging with
one another as you walk?" And they stood still, their faces downcast.
18 One of them, whose name was Cleopas, replied, "Are you the only
visitor in Jerusalem who has not heard what has taken place there
lately?" 19 He asked them, "What things?" They told him, "The things
about Jesus the Nazarene, who was a prophet, mighty in deed and
word before God and all the people; 20 how our chief priests and rulers
handed him over to be condemned to death and crucified him. 21 But
we had been hoping that he was the one who would redeem Israel.
And besides all this, it is now the third day since these things took
place. 22 Moreover, some women from our group astounded us. They
went to the tomb early in the morning, 23 and when they did not find
his body, they came back saying they had even seen a vision of angels,
who said that he is alive. 24 Some of those with us went off to the tomb
and found it just as the women had said; but him they did not see." 25
He told them, "How foolish you are, and how slow in your hearts to
believe all that the prophets declared! 26 Did the Messiah not have to
suffer these things before entering his glory?" 27 And beginning from
Moses and from all the prophets, he explained to them the things
concerning himself in all the Scriptures.
28 As they approached the village they were headed for, he behaved
as if he were going on farther. 29 But they pressed him: "Stay with us,
because it is nearly evening and the day is almost over." So he went in
to stay with them. 30 When he had reclined at table with them, he took
the bread, blessed it, broke it, and began handing it to them. 31 Then
their eyes were opened, and they recognized him; and he vanished

from their sight. 32 And they said to one another, “Did not our hearts
burn inside us as he spoke to us along the way, as he laid open the
Scriptures for us?” 33 They got up that same hour and returned to
Jerusalem, and they found the Eleven and those with them gathered
together, 34 who were saying, “The Lord has really been raised, and he
has appeared to Simon!” 35 They in turn related the things on the road,
and how they had come to know him in the breaking of the bread.
36 While they were still talking about these things, he himself stood
among them [[and said to them, “Peace to you.”]][g] 37 But they were
alarmed and frightened, supposing that what they saw was a spirit.
38 He said to them, “Why are you troubled, and why do doubts arise
in your hearts? 39 Look at my hands and my feet, that it is I myself.
Touch me and see; for a spirit does not have flesh and bones, as you
see that I have.” 40 [[And when he had said this, he showed them his
hands and his feet.]][h] 41 While in their joy they still could not believe
it and were marveling, he said to them, “Do you have anything here
to eat?” 42 They gave him a piece of broiled fish,[i] 43 and taking it he ate
it as they watched.
44 He said to them, “This is what I meant when I told you, while I was
still with you, that everything written about me in the Law of Moses,
the Prophets and the Psalms had to be fulfilled.” 45 Then he opened
their minds to understand the Scriptures, 46 He said to them, “So it
stands written: the Messiah is to suffer and rise from the dead on the
third day, 47 and that repentance for[j] the forgiveness of sins is to be
proclaimed in his name to all the nations, beginning from Jerusalem.
48 You are witnesses of these things. 49 And look, I am sending forth
the promise of my Father on you; you, however, are to remain in the
city until you have been clothed with power from on high.”
50 Then he led them out as far as Bethany, and lifting up his hands
he blessed them. 51 While he was blessing them, he parted from them
[[and was carried up into heaven]].[k] 52 And they [[worshiped him
and]][l] returned to Jerusalem with great joy, 53 and they were contin-
ually in the temple, blessing God.[m]

Notes

- a (24:3) Of the Lord Jesus: these words are placed in double brackets in the Westcott–Hort text as one of the "Western non-interpolations" in Luke 24 (see also 24:6, 12, 36, 40, 51, 52). They are absent only from Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses, but present in P75 (as reported), Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and nearly all other manuscripts; NA and SBLGNT print them. Some manuscripts read "of Jesus."
- b (24:6) He is not here, but has been raised: a "Western non-interpolation" (see 24:3); lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses, but present in P75 (as reported), Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and almost all others. The verb may also be rendered "he has risen."
- c (24:9) From the tomb: the Westcott–Hort text brackets these words, which are lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin and Armenian witnesses.
- d (24:10) Magdalene: "of Magdala," a town on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee; the name may mean "tower."
- e (24:12) The whole of 24:12 is a "Western non-interpolation" in the Westcott–Hort text (see 24:3); it is lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses, but present in P75 (as reported), Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and nearly all others, and is printed by NA and SBLGNT. Compare John 20:3–10.
- f (24:13) About seven miles: Greek "sixty stadia," about 11 kilometers. Some manuscripts, including Sinaiticus, read "one hundred sixty stadia" (about 18 miles; 30 kilometers).
- g (24:36) The words "and said to them, 'Peace to you'" are a "Western non-interpolation" in the Westcott–Hort text (see 24:3); lacking in Codex Bezae and some Old Latin witnesses, but present in P75 (as reported) and nearly all others. Some manuscripts add, "It is I; do not be afraid" (compare John 6:20).
- h (24:40) The whole of 24:40 is a "Western non-interpolation" in the Westcott–Hort text (see 24:3); lacking in Codex Bezae, some Old Latin witnesses, and the Old Syriac, but present in P75 (as reported) and nearly all others. Compare John 20:20.
- i (24:42) Broiled fish: many later manuscripts add "and some honeycomb."
- j (24:47) For: Greek *eis*, the reading of the Westcott–Hort text (with P75, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus); many manuscripts read "and" (*kai*), "repentance and forgiveness of sins."
- k (24:51) And was carried up into heaven: a "Western non-interpolation" in the Westcott–Hort text (see 24:3); lacking in the original hand of Sinaiticus, Codex Bezae, and some Old Latin and Syriac witnesses, but present in P75 (as reported), Vaticanus, and most others.
- l (24:52) Worshiped him and: a "Western non-interpolation" in the Westcott–Hort text (see 24:3); lacking in Codex Bezae, some Old Latin witnesses, and the Old Syriac, but present in P75 (as reported), Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and most others.
- m (24:53) Blessing God: many manuscripts read "praising and blessing God"; Codex Bezae reads "praising God." Many later manuscripts add "Amen."

John

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 In the beginning was the Word,[a] and the Word was with God, and the
Word was God.[b] 2 He was in the beginning with God. 3 Through him
everything came to be; without him not a single thing came to be.[c] 4
What has come into being in him was life, and the life was the light
of humankind. 5 The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness
has not overcome[d] it.
6 There came a man sent from God; his name was John.[e] 7 He came
as a witness, to speak for the light, so that all people could come to
believe through him. 8 He himself was not the light; he came to bear
witness about the light. 9 The true light, which gives light to every
person, was coming into the world.[f]
10 He was present in the world, and through him the world came to
be, yet the world failed to recognize him. 11 He came to his own home,
and those who were his own did not welcome him. 12 But to all who
did receive him, to those who believe in his name, he gave the right
to become children of God, 13 who were born not of blood, nor of the
will of the flesh, nor of a husband's will, but of God.
14 And the Word became human and made his dwelling[g] among us.
We saw his glory, the glory of the one and only Son[h] from the Father,
full of grace and truth. 15 John testifies concerning him; he cried
aloud, "This is the man I meant when I said, 'He who comes after me
has gone ahead of me, for he was before me.'" 16 Out of his fullness
we all have received, one grace after another.[i] 17 For the Law was
given through Moses;[j] grace and truth came into being through Jesus
Christ.[k] 18 No one has seen God at any time; the only Son, himself
God,[l] who rests at the Father's side,[m] he is the one who has made
him known.

19 This is the testimony of John, when the Jews[n] sent priests and
Levites from Jerusalem to ask him, "Who are you?" 20 He confessed
and did not deny; he confessed, "I am not the Messiah."[o] 21 They asked
him, "What then? Are you Elijah?"[p] He says, "I am not." "Are you the
Prophet?"[q] He answered, "No." 22 So they said to him, "Who are you?
Give us an answer to take back to those who sent us. What do you
say about yourself?" 23 He said, "I am the voice of one crying out in
the wilderness, 'Make straight the way of the Lord,'[r] just as Isaiah[s]
the prophet said." 24 Now they had been sent from the Pharisees.[t] 25 So
they asked him, "If you are not the Messiah, or Elijah, or the Prophet,
why are you baptizing?" 26 John replied to them, "I baptize in water.
Standing among you is one you do not know, 27 who comes after me;
I am not worthy to loosen the strap of his sandal." 28 These things
took place in Bethany[u], east of the Jordan, the place where John was
baptizing.
29 The next day he sees Jesus coming toward him and says, "Look, the
Lamb of God,[v] who takes away the sin of the world! 30 He is the one
about whom I said, 'A man is coming after me who has gone ahead
of me, because he was before me.' 31 I myself did not know him; but
it was so that he might be revealed to Israel that I came baptizing
with water." 32 And John bore witness: "I have seen the Spirit coming
down like a dove out of heaven, and it remained on him. 33 I did not
recognize him myself. But the one who sent me to baptize in water
said to me, 'You will see the Spirit descend and stay on someone. That
is the one who baptizes in the Holy Spirit.' 34 And I have seen, and
have borne witness, that this is the Son of God."[w]
35 The following day John was there again, with two of his disciples,
36 and as he watched Jesus walking by, he says, "Look, the Lamb of
God!" 37 When the two disciples heard what he said, they went after
Jesus. 38 Jesus turned, and seeing them following, he says to them,
"What are you looking for?" They said to him, "Rabbi" (which, trans-
lated, means Teacher), "where are you staying?" 39 "Come," he says to
them, "and you will see." So they went and saw where he lodged, and
they remained with him for the rest of that day. It was about four
in the afternoon.[x] 40 Andrew,[y] the brother of Simon Peter, was one of

the two who heard John and followed Jesus. 41 He first finds his own brother Simon[z] and says to him, “We have found the Messiah” (which, translated, is Christ).[aa] 42 He brought him to Jesus. Jesus looked at him and said, “You are Simon the son of John.[ab] You will be called Cephas” (which is translated Peter).[ac]

43 The next day Jesus decided to set out for Galilee. He finds Philip[ad] and says to him, “Follow me.” 44 Philip came from Bethsaida,[ae] the hometown of Andrew and Peter. 45 Philip finds Nathanael[af] and tells him, “We have found the one Moses wrote of in the Law, and the prophets also: Jesus son of Joseph,[ag] from Nazareth.”[ah] 46 Nathanael said to him, “From Nazareth can anything good come?” Philip says to him, “Come and see.” 47 Jesus saw Nathanael coming toward him and says of him, “Here truly is an Israelite in whom there is no deceit!”[ai] 48 Nathanael asked him, “How do you know me?” Jesus replied, “I saw you before Philip called you, when you were sitting under the fig tree.” 49 Nathanael answered him, “Rabbi, you are the Son of God! You are King of Israel!” 50 Jesus answered him, “Because I told you I saw you beneath the fig tree, you believe? You will see greater things than these.” 51 And he says to him, “Amen, amen,[aj] I tell you all,[ak] you will see heaven opened and the angels of God going up and coming down on the Son of Man.”[al]

Notes

- a (1:1) The Word: Greek *logos*, “word,” “speech,” or “reason.” In the Greek Old Testament God creates by his word (Gen 1:3; Ps 33:6) and his word or wisdom is personified (Prov 8:22–31; Wis 9:1–2; 18:15); Greek philosophers also used *logos* for the rational principle ordering the world. John applies the term to the one who became flesh (1:14). It is used of him in this sense only in 1:1 and 1:14 (compare 1 John 1:1; Rev 19:13).
- b (1:1) The Word was God: Greek *theos ēn ho logos*. The word *theos* has no article and stands first for emphasis; the construction identifies the Word as sharing God’s nature while distinguishing him from “God” (the Father) in the preceding clause. It does not mean “a god.”
- c (1:3) The punctuation of verses 3–4 is ancient and disputed, because the earliest manuscripts had little or none. The Westcott–Hort text, with many early writers, attaches the final words of verse 3 to verse 4 (“What has come into being in him was life”), as here. Many later manuscripts and versions divide the text differently,

ending verse 3 after the words “has come into being,” and starting verse 4 with “In him was life.”

- d (1:5) Overcome: Greek *katelaben* can mean “grasp,” “comprehend,” or “seize, overcome.” Both senses may be intended.
- e (1:6) John: from Hebrew *Yohanan*, “Yahweh has been gracious.” This is John the Baptist (compare Matt 3:1), not the disciple traditionally connected with this Gospel, who is never named in it.
- f (1:9) Or “He was the true light, which gives light to every person coming into the world.” The Greek *erchomenon* can go with “light” or with “every person.”
- g (1:14) Pitched his tent: Greek *eskēnōsen*, “tented,” “tabernacled.” The word recalls the tabernacle (Greek *skēnē*) where God’s glory dwelt among Israel (Exod 25:8–9; 40:34–35).
- h (1:14) The only Son: Greek *monogenēs*, “only,” “one of a kind,” “unique,” used of an only child (Luke 7:12; Heb 11:17). The older rendering “only begotten” comes from the Latin *unigenitus*. Here and in 1:18; 3:16, 18 it describes Jesus’ unique relationship to the Father.
- i (1:16) One grace after another: Greek *charin anti charitos*, literally “grace in place of grace,” meaning one gift following another, or perhaps the grace of the new covenant replacing that given through Moses (1:17).
- j (1:17) Moses: the name is explained in Exod 2:10; it may come from an Egyptian word meaning “born of” or “son.”
- k (1:17) Jesus Christ: *Jesus* is the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (*Yehoshua*, Joshua), “Yahweh saves.” *Christ* translates Greek *Christos*, “Anointed One,” the equivalent of Hebrew *mashiach*, “Messiah” (see 1:41). As in Matthew, *Christos* is rendered “Messiah” where it functions as a title and “Christ” where it is part of Jesus’ name.
- l (1:18) The only Son, himself God: literally “only (*monogenēs*) God.” This is the reading of the earliest manuscripts, including P66 and P75 (about AD 200), Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus, followed by Westcott–Hort; P75 and some others have “the only God” with the article. Alexandrinus, the great majority of later manuscripts, and many versions read “the only Son” (*monogenēs huios*). Since *monogenēs* used by itself regularly implies “only son” (1:14), the reading “only God” is taken here as “the only Son, himself God.” Scholarly review recommended.
- m (1:18) At the Father’s side: literally “in (or into) the bosom of the Father,” a picture of intimacy, like a guest reclining at table next to the host (compare 13:23).
- n (1:19) The Jews: Greek *hoi Ioudaioi*, “the Jews” or “the Judeans.” In John the term often refers to the religious authorities in Jerusalem who opposed Jesus (as here, 1:19, 24), and sometimes to the people of Judea; at other times it simply means the Jewish people (2:6, 13; 4:9, 22). Jesus, his disciples, and the Gospel’s first witnesses were themselves Jews.
- o (1:20) The Messiah: Greek *ho christos*, “the Anointed One.”

- p (1:21) Elijah: “my God is Yahweh.” Mal 4:5 (3:23 in Hebrew) promised that Elijah would return before the day of Yahweh.
- q (1:21) The Prophet: the prophet like Moses promised in Deut 18:15–18 (compare 6:14; 7:40).
- r (1:23) Isa 40:3, in a form close to the Greek Old Testament (“make straight” combines two verbs of that verse). In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.
- s (1:23) Isaiah: “Yahweh is salvation.”
- t (1:24) Pharisees: from Hebrew or Aramaic *perushim*, probably “separated ones.” A lay movement devoted to the careful keeping of the Law and its traditions.
- u (1:28) Bethany: a place east of the Jordan River whose location is unknown; it is not the Bethany near Jerusalem (11:1, 18). Some later manuscripts read *Bethabara* (“place of crossing”), following Origen. The name *Bethany* may mean “house of figs” or “house of the poor” (uncertain).
- v (1:29) The Lamb of God: the image may recall the Passover lamb (Exod 12; compare 19:36), the servant led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isa 53:7), or the lamb God provides (Gen 22:8).
- w (1:34) The Son of God: a few early witnesses, including Sinaiticus (first hand) and probably P5, read “the Chosen One of God” (compare Isa 42:1).
- x (1:39) About four in the afternoon: literally “about the tenth hour.” Hours of the day were usually counted from sunrise, about 6 a.m., which gives four in the afternoon. Some interpreters have argued that John reckons hours from midnight, as Roman legal practice sometimes did, which would make the time about 10 a.m.; but the evidence for such a reckoning is debated, and most interpreters count from sunrise in John as in the other Gospels (compare 4:6, 52; 19:14).
- y (1:40) Andrew: a Greek name, “manly.”
- z (1:41) Simon: Greek form of Hebrew *Shimon*, “he has heard” (Gen 29:33).
- aa (1:41) Messiah … Christ: Greek *Messias*, a transliteration of Hebrew *mashiach* or Aramaic *meshicha*, “anointed one”; *Christos* is the Greek translation of it. Only John uses the word *Messias* in the New Testament (here and 4:25).
- ab (1:42) The son of John: so the earliest manuscripts and Westcott–Hort; many later manuscripts read “son of Jonah” (as in Matt 16:17). *Jonah* means “dove.”
- ac (1:42) Cephas … Peter: Aramaic *Kepha* and Greek *Petros* both mean “rock” or “stone.”
- ad (1:43) Philip: a Greek name, “lover of horses.”
- ae (1:44) Bethsaida: “house of fishing” or “house of the hunt,” a town at the north end of the Sea of Galilee, east of the Jordan.
- af (1:45) Nathanael: “God has given.” He is not mentioned in the other Gospels; some have identified him with Bartholomew.
- ag (1:45) Joseph: “may he add” (Gen 30:24).

- ah (1:45) Nazareth: a small village in the hills of lower Galilee, not mentioned in the Old Testament or in other sources before the Gospels; the meaning of its name is uncertain.
- ai (1:47) No deceit: perhaps a contrast with Jacob, the deceiver, who was renamed Israel (Gen 27:35; 32:28); compare 1:51.
- aj (1:51) Amen, amen: Hebrew *amen*, "surely, truly," used by Jesus to introduce a solemn statement. Only in John is it doubled (twenty-five times).
- ak (1:51) You all: the Greek "you" is plural here, though Jesus is speaking to Nathanael.
- al (1:51) Compare Jacob's dream at Bethel (Gen 28:12). *Son of Man* (Aramaic *bar enash*, "human being") is Jesus' usual way of referring to himself; compare Dan 7:13–14.

Chapter 2

1 On the third day a marriage was held in Cana[a] of Galilee, and
the mother of Jesus was there. 2 Jesus also had been invited to the
wedding, along with his disciples. 3 When the wine ran short, the
mother of Jesus says to him, "They have no wine." 4 Jesus said to her,
"Woman,[b] how does this concern you and me? My time has not come
yet." 5 His mother says to the servants, "Whatever he tells you, do it."
6 Six stone water jars stood nearby, used for the purification rites of
the Jews, each able to hold twenty or thirty gallons.[c] 7 Jesus says to
them, "Fill the jars with water." And they filled them to the brim. 8
Then he says to them, "Now draw some out, and carry it to the master
of the feast." So they carried it. 9 The master of the feast tasted the
water that had turned into wine, not knowing its source (though the
servants who had drawn the water knew). He called the bridegroom
10 and says to him, "Everyone sets out the good wine first, and when
the guests have drunk freely, the poorer wine. You have kept the good
wine until now." 11 Jesus did this at Cana in Galilee as the first of his
signs.[d] He showed his glory, and his disciples put their faith in him.
12 After this he went down to Capernaum,[e] he and his mother and his
brothers[f] and his disciples, and they stayed there for a few days.
13 When the Jewish Passover[g] was approaching, Jesus went up to
Jerusalem.[h] 14 In the temple he found those who were selling cattle,
sheep, and doves, and the money changers sitting there. 15 Making
a whip of cords, he drove everyone out of the temple courts, sheep

and cattle alike; he scattered the money changers' coins and turned their tables over. 16 And to those selling the doves he said, "Take these things out of here! Stop making my Father's house a house of trade." 17 His disciples remembered that it is written, "Zeal for your house will consume me."[i]

18 So the Jews responded to him, "What sign do you show us, to justify your doing these things?" 19 Jesus answered them, "Destroy this sanctuary,[j] and in three days I will raise it up." 20 The Jews replied, "It took forty-six years[k] to build this temple, and you will raise it in three days?" 21 But he was speaking about the sanctuary of his body. 22 So when he was raised from the dead, his disciples remembered that he had said this, and they believed the Scripture and the word that Jesus had spoken.

23 While he was in Jerusalem at the Passover, during the festival, many believed in his name when they saw the signs that he was doing. 24 Jesus, however, did not trust himself to them, since he knew everyone, 25 and he had no need for anyone to bear witness about humankind, for he himself knew what was in each person.

Notes

- a (2:1) Cana: a village in Galilee, probably Khirbet Qana, about 8 miles (13 km) north of Nazareth. The name may mean "reed."
- b (2:4) Woman: a respectful form of address in Greek (compare 19:26; 20:15), though unusual from a son to his mother. *What is that to me and to you?* is a Semitic idiom (compare Judg 11:12; 1 Kgs 17:18) that marks a distance between the speakers: "What concern is that of ours?"
- c (2:6) Twenty or thirty gallons: literally "two or three measures." The Greek *metrētēs* was a liquid measure of about 9 gallons (39 L), so each jar held about 75–115 liters, and the six together about 120–180 gallons.
- d (2:11) Signs: Greek *sēmeia*. John calls Jesus' miracles "signs," pointing beyond themselves to who he is (20:30–31).
- e (2:12) Capernaum: from Hebrew *Kefar Nahum*, "village of Nahum" ("comfort"), on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee.
- f (2:12) His brothers: see 7:3–5. Their exact relation to Jesus (sons of Mary and Joseph, of Joseph by an earlier marriage, or cousins) has been understood differently in different church traditions.
- g (2:13) Passover: Greek *pascha*, from Hebrew *pesach*, the spring festival commemorating the exodus from Egypt, celebrated on the fourteenth of Nisan

(March–April). John mentions three Passovers during Jesus' ministry (here, 6:4, and 11:55).

- h (2:13) Jerusalem: the meaning of the name is uncertain, perhaps "foundation of Shalem" or "city of peace."
- i (2:17) Ps 69:9 (68:10 in the Greek Old Testament). The psalm has "has consumed"; John uses the future.
- j (2:19) Sanctuary: Greek *naos*, the temple building proper, as distinct from *hieron*, the whole temple complex (2:14–15).
- k (2:20) Forty-six years: Herod the Great began rebuilding the temple in about 20–19 BC, which places this conversation about AD 27–28. The work was not finished until about AD 63.

Chapter 3

1 Among the Pharisees there was a man named Nicodemus,[a] a leader
of the Jews. 2 He came to Jesus at night and said, "Rabbi, we are sure
you are a teacher who has come from God, since no one is able to
do the signs you are doing unless God is with him." 3 Jesus answered
him, "Amen, amen, I tell you, unless someone is born from above,[b]
he cannot see the kingdom of God." 4 Nicodemus says to him, "How
can a person be born when he is old? Surely he cannot go back a
second time into his mother's womb and be born?" 5 Jesus answered,
"Amen, amen, I tell you, unless someone is born of water and Spirit,
he cannot enter the kingdom of God. 6 What is born of the flesh is
flesh, and what is born of the Spirit is spirit. 7 Do not be amazed that
I told you, 'All of you must be born from above.' 8 The wind[c] blows
where it likes. Its sound reaches your ears, yet you have no idea where
it begins or where it ends. Everyone who is born of the Spirit is like
that." 9 Nicodemus answered him, "How can such things come about?"
10 Jesus replied, "You are a teacher of Israel, and yet you do not grasp
this? 11 Amen, amen, I tell you, what we know we speak, and what we
have seen we declare, and still you people refuse our testimony. 12 If
you do not believe when I have spoken to you of things on earth, how
will you believe when I speak of things in heaven? 13 No one has ever
ascended to heaven except the one who descended from heaven, the
Son of Man.[d] 14 And just as Moses raised up the snake in the desert,[e]
even so must the Son of Man be raised up,[f] 15 in order that each one
who believes may possess eternal life in him.[g]

16 “For God loved the world in this way: he gave his only Son,[h] so that
whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life. 17 God
sent the Son into the world, not to pronounce a verdict against it,
but so that the world could be rescued by him. 18 Whoever believes in
him does not come under judgment; whoever does not believe stands
judged already, for not having believed in the name of God’s only
Son. 19 And this is the judgment: the light has come into the world,
and people loved the darkness more than the light, because what they
did was evil. 20 For everyone who practices wicked things hates the
light and will not come to the light, lest his deeds be exposed. 21 But
the one who practices the truth comes to the light, so that his deeds
may be shown to have been wrought in God.”
22 After this Jesus and his disciples went into the land of Judea, and
he spent time there with them and was baptizing. 23 John also was
baptizing at Aenon near Salim,[i] since there was much water in that
place, and people were coming to be baptized. 24 John had not yet been
put in prison at that time.
25 A dispute then arose between John’s disciples and a Jew[j] over
purification. 26 So they went to John and told him, “Rabbi, that man
who was with you beyond the Jordan, to whom you bore witness, is
now baptizing, and the whole world is flocking to him.” 27 John replied,
“A person can receive nothing unless it has been granted him from
heaven. 28 You can testify for me yourselves that I said, ‘I am not the
Messiah; rather, I have been sent before him.’ 29 The bridegroom is the
one who has the bride. The bridegroom’s friend, who stands by and
listens for him, is overjoyed at the bridegroom’s voice. So this joy of
mine is now complete. 30 He must grow greater, and I must grow less.”[k]
31 The one who comes from above is above everyone. Whoever is from
the earth is earthly and speaks about earthly things. The one who
comes from heaven is above everyone. 32 What he has seen and heard,
to that he bears witness, yet his testimony no one receives. 33 Whoever
has accepted his testimony has set his seal to this: that God is true.
34 For the one whom God has sent speaks the words of God, since he
does not give the Spirit by measure. 35 The Father loves the Son and
has put everything into his hand. 36 Anyone who believes in the Son

possesses eternal life; anyone who refuses to obey the Son will not see life, and God's wrath stays upon him.

Notes

- a (3:1) Nicodemus: a Greek name, "victor over the people."
- b (3:3) From above: Greek *anōthen* means both "from above" and "again, anew." Nicodemus takes it in the second sense (3:4); Jesus means the first (3:31).
- c (3:8) Wind: Greek *pneuma* means both "wind" and "spirit," as does Hebrew *ruach*.
- d (3:13) Many later manuscripts add "who is in heaven." The Westcott–Hort text, with P66, P75, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, does not include it.
- e (3:14) Num 21:8–9.
- f (3:14) Raised up: Greek *hypsōthēnai*, "lifted up,", used in John both of being raised up on the cross and of exaltation to glory (8:28; 12:32–34).
- g (3:15) Or "so that each one who believes in him may possess eternal life." Some interpreters end Jesus' words at 3:15 and take 3:16–21 as the evangelist's comment; the Greek did not mark quotations. The same uncertainty applies to 3:31–36.
- h (3:16) His only Son: Greek *ton huion ton monogenē*; see the note on 1:14.
- i (3:23) Aenon near Salim: *Aenon* means "springs." The location is uncertain, perhaps in the Jordan valley south of Scythopolis, or in Samaria near Shechem. *Salim* may be related to *shalom*, "peace."
- j (3:25) A Jew: so the Westcott–Hort text and most manuscripts; P66, Sinaiticus (first hand), and some others read "the Jews."
- k (3:30) Grow greater ... grow less: or "increase ... decrease."

Chapter 4

1 Now when the Lord[a] learned that the Pharisees had heard that Jesus
was making and baptizing more disciples than John 2 (though in fact
it was not Jesus himself who baptized, but his disciples), 3 he left Judea
and went away again to Galilee. 4 He had to pass through Samaria.[b]
5 So he comes to a town of Samaria called Sychar,[c] near the piece of
land that Jacob[d] gave to his son Joseph. 6 Jacob's well[e] was there, and
Jesus, worn out from the journey, was sitting just as he was beside
the well. It was about noon.[f]
7 A woman of Samaria comes to draw water. Jesus says to her, "Give
me a drink." 8 His disciples had gone away into the town to purchase
food. 9 So the Samaritan woman says to him, "How is it that you, a Jew,
ask for a drink from me, a Samaritan woman?" (Jews, you see, have
no dealings with Samaritans.)[g] 10 Jesus answered her, "If you knew the

gift of God, and who it is that says to you, 'Give me a drink,' you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water."[h]
11 She said to him, "Sir,[i] you have no rope or bucket, and this well
is deep. So where can you find that living water? 12 Surely you are
not greater than our ancestor Jacob, who gave us this well? He drank
from it himself, as did his sons and his flocks." 13 Jesus answered her,
"Everyone who drinks of this water will be thirsty again; 14 but anyone
who drinks the water that I will give him will never thirst again;
rather, the water I will give him will become within him a spring of
water leaping up to eternal life." 15 The woman said to him, "Sir, give
me this water, so I will never be thirsty again and never have to come
here to draw water."
16 He says to her, "Go, call your husband, and come back here." 17 The
woman answered him, "I have no husband." Jesus says to her, "You
spoke rightly in saying, 'I have no husband,' 18 You have had five
husbands, and the man you now have is no husband of yours. In this
you have spoken truly." 19 "Sir," the woman says to him, "I perceive
you are a prophet. 20 Our ancestors worshiped on this mountain,[j]
yet you Jews claim that Jerusalem is where people must worship." 21
Jesus says to her, "Woman, believe me: the hour is coming when it
will be neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem that you worship
the Father. 22 You worship something you do not know; we worship
something we know, since it is from the Jews that salvation comes.
23 But an hour is coming, and is here now, when the true worshipers
will worship the Father in spirit and truth; for the Father is seeking
people such as these to worship him. 24 God is spirit, and those who
worship him must worship in spirit and truth." 25 The woman says to
him, "I know that Messiah is coming" (the one called Christ). "When
he comes, he will declare everything to us." 26 Jesus says to her, "I am
he,[k] the one who is speaking to you."
27 At that point his disciples arrived, and they were surprised to find
him speaking with a woman. Still, none of them said, "What are you
after?" or, "Why do you speak with her?" 28 The woman then left her
water jar, went off into the town, and says to the people, 29 "Come, see

a man who told me everything I ever did! Can this be the Messiah?"
30 They went out of the town and were making their way to him.
31 Meanwhile the disciples were urging him, "Rabbi, eat." 32 But he said
to them, "I have food to eat that you know nothing about." 33 The
disciples therefore began asking one another, "Has anyone brought
him food?" 34 Jesus says to them, "My food is doing the will of him
who sent me, and finishing his work. 35 Do you not say, 'Four months
more, and then comes the harvest'? Look, I tell you, raise your eyes
and see the fields: they are white for harvest already. 36 Already the
reaper is drawing his pay and bringing in a harvest for eternal life,
that sower and reaper alike may be glad. 37 In this the saying is true:
'One person sows, another reaps.' 38 I sent you to reap what you have
not labored for. Others have labored, and you have entered into their
labor."
39 Many Samaritans from that town trusted in him, because the
woman had testified, "He told me everything I ever did." 40 When
therefore the Samaritans came to him, they begged him to remain
with them, and he remained there for two days. 41 And far more
believed because of his own word. 42 They said to the woman, "It is
no longer your words that make us believe. We have now heard him
ourselves, and we know that this man truly is the Savior of the world."
43 After the two days he left there for Galilee. 44 (For Jesus himself had
testified that a prophet has no honor in his own homeland.) 45 When
he arrived in Galilee, the Galileans received him, having seen all he
did at Jerusalem during the feast, since they too had gone up for the
feast.
46 Then he came once more to Cana in Galilee, where he had turned
the water into wine. At Capernaum there was a certain royal official[1]
whose son was ill. 47 He heard that Jesus had come out of Judea into
Galilee, so he went and pleaded with him to come and heal his son,
who was about to die. 48 So Jesus said to him, "Unless you all see signs
and wonders, you will not believe at all." 49 The official says to him,
"Sir, come down before my little boy dies." 50 Jesus says to him, "Go;
your son lives." The man believed the word that Jesus spoke to him
and set off. 51 While he was still on his way down, his servants met

him and told him that his boy was living. 52 He inquired of them at what hour the boy had started to improve. “Yesterday, at one in the afternoon,”[m] they said, “the fever went from him.” 53 The father realized that this was the very hour when Jesus had said to him, “Your son lives.” And he himself believed, along with his whole household. 54 This again was the second sign that Jesus did after coming from Judea into Galilee.

Notes

- a (4:1) The Lord: Greek *ho kyrios*, used here of Jesus. Many manuscripts, including P66 and P75 as reported, read “Jesus”; the Westcott–Hort text reads “the Lord.”
- b (4:4) Samaria: the region between Judea and Galilee, named after the city of Samaria (Hebrew *Shomron*, perhaps “watch-post”). Jews traveling between Judea and Galilee sometimes went around it by way of the Jordan valley.
- c (4:5) Sychar: probably the village of Askar near ancient Shechem, at the foot of Mount Gerizim; some identify it with Shechem itself.
- d (4:5) Jacob: Hebrew *Yaakov*, explained in Gen 25:26 and 27:36 as “heel-grabber” or “one who supplants.” For the land given to Joseph, see Gen 33:19; 48:22; Josh 24:32.
- e (4:6) Well: Greek *pēgē*, “spring,” here and in 4:14; in 4:11–12 the word is *phrear*, “well, cistern.” The well was fed by an underground spring.
- f (4:6) About noon: literally “about the sixth hour,” counting from sunrise (about 6 a.m.). On the view that John counts from midnight, which would make the time about 6 a.m. or 6 p.m., see the note on 1:39.
- g (4:9) Many interpreters take the parenthesis as the evangelist’s comment. The words *sunchrōntai* may mean “have no dealings with” or, more narrowly, “do not use vessels in common with.” Sinaiticus (first hand) and a few other witnesses omit the sentence; the Westcott–Hort text places it in brackets.
- h (4:10) Living water: an idiom for running water from a spring or stream, as opposed to still water in a cistern; Jesus uses it of the life he gives (compare 7:37–39; Jer 2:13).
- i (4:11) Sir: Greek *kyrie*, which can be a polite address (“sir”) or a title (“Lord”).
- j (4:20) This mountain: Mount Gerizim, near Sychar, where the Samaritans had built a temple (destroyed about 110 BC) and continued to worship (compare Deut 11:29; 27:12).
- k (4:26) I am he: literally “I am” (Greek *egō eimi*). See the note on 6:20 and 8:58.
- l (4:46) Royal official: Greek *basilikos*, an officer in the service of the king, here probably Herod Antipas, tetrarch of Galilee.
- m (4:52) One in the afternoon: literally “the seventh hour,” counting from sunrise. See the note on 1:39.

Chapter 5

1 Some time later there was a festival of the Jews,[a] and Jesus went up
to Jerusalem. 2 Now in Jerusalem, by the Sheep Gate, there is a pool,
called in Hebrew[b] Bethzatha,[c] which has five colonnades. 3 In these
lay a crowd of invalids: blind, lame, withered.[d] 4 [e] 5 One man there
had been in his illness thirty-eight years. 6 When Jesus saw him lying
there and knew that he had already been that way a long time, he
says to him, "Do you want to become well?" 7 The sick man replied,
"Sir, I have no one to put me in the pool once the water is stirred.
By the time I get there, someone else has already gone in ahead of
me." 8 "Rise," Jesus says to him, "take up your pallet and walk about." 9
Immediately the man was healed. He picked up his mat and walked.
That day was a Sabbath.[f]
10 The Jews therefore told the healed man, "This is the Sabbath; it is not
lawful for you to be carrying your pallet." 11 But he answered them,
"The man who made me well, he is the one who told me, 'Take up
your pallet and walk.'" 12 They questioned him, "Who is the man that
told you, 'Take it up and walk'?" 13 But the man who had been healed
had no idea who it was, for Jesus had slipped away, there being a
crowd in the place. 14 Afterward Jesus finds him in the temple and
said to him, "See, you have become well. Sin no more, so that nothing
worse befalls you." 15 The man went off and told the Jews that it was
Jesus who had made him well. 16 That is why the Jews began to hound
Jesus: he was doing such things on a Sabbath. 17 But Jesus answered
them, "My Father is at work until now, and I am at work too." 18 This
made the Jews try all the harder to kill him. He was not only breaking
the Sabbath; he was also calling God his own Father, and so making
himself equal with God.
19 So Jesus responded to them, "Amen, amen, I tell you, the Son is able
to do nothing by himself, except what he sees the Father doing; for
whatever things the Father does, these the Son does in like manner.
20 The Father has affection for the Son and lets him see everything he
himself is doing, and greater works than these he will let him see, to
your amazement. 21 For just as the Father raises the dead and gives
them life, so the Son too gives life to whomever he wills. 22 Nor does

the Father judge anyone; he has entrusted all judgment to the Son,
23 so that everyone will honor the Son just as they honor the Father.
Anyone who does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who
sent him. 24 Truly, truly, I say to you, anyone who listens to what I say
and believes the one who sent me has eternal life. That person will
not be judged but has already passed from death to life. 25 Truly, truly,
I say to you, a time is coming, and has already come, when the dead
will hear the voice of the Son of God, and those who listen will live.
26 For as the Father has life in himself, so he has granted the Son also
to have life in himself. 27 And he has given him authority to execute
judgment, because he is the Son of Man.[g] 28 Do not be amazed at this;
the hour is coming when everyone lying in the graves will hear his
voice 29 and will come out. Those who did good will rise to live, and
those who did evil will rise to be judged.
30 "On my own I can do nothing. I judge only as I am told, and my
judgment is fair, because I am not seeking my own will but the will
of the one who sent me. 31 If I bear witness about myself, my witness
is not true.[h] 32 Someone else testifies about me, and I know that his
testimony about me is true. 33 You yourselves sent messengers to John,
and his testimony was to the truth. 34 Not that the testimony I accept
is from a human being; but I say these things so that you may be
saved. 35 John was a lamp, burning and giving light, and for a short
time you were glad to enjoy his light. 36 But the testimony I have is
greater than John's. The works that the Father has given me to bring
to completion, the very works I am doing, testify about me that the
Father has sent me. 37 The Father who sent me has himself testified
about me. You have never heard his voice or seen his form, 38 and his
word you do not have abiding in you, because you do not believe
the one he sent. 39 You pore over the Scriptures[i] because you suppose
you possess eternal life in them; yet these are the very writings that
testify about me. 40 Yet you are unwilling to come to me to have life.
41 Glory from human beings I do not receive. 42 But I have come to
know you, and the love of God is not in you. 43 I have come in my
Father's name, and you do not receive me; if someone else comes in
his own name, him you will receive. 44 How are you able to believe,

you who accept honor from each other and do not look for the honor that is from the only God?[j] 45 Do not imagine that it is I who will bring charges against you before the Father. The one who brings charges against you is Moses, in whom you have placed your hope. 46 For if you believed Moses, you would believe me, for it was about me that he wrote. 47 But if you do not believe his writings, how will you believe my words?"

Notes

- a (5:1) A festival of the Jews: the festival is not named. Sinaiticus and some other manuscripts read "the festival," which would probably mean Passover or Tabernacles.
- b (5:2) In Hebrew: that is, in the Hebrew or Aramaic language spoken in Judea (so also 19:13, 17; 20:16).
- c (5:2) Bethzatha: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and a few others. Other manuscripts read *Bethesda* ("house of mercy," or perhaps "house of the outpouring"), and P66, P75 and Vaticanus are reported to read *Bethsaida*. *Bethzatha* may mean "house of olives," or be the name of the northern quarter of the city (Bezetha). A double pool with five porticoes has been excavated near the Church of St. Anne, north of the temple area.
- d (5:3) Withered: that is, paralyzed. Many later manuscripts add a clause at the end of verse 3 about waiting for the water to move, and add a verse 4 saying that an angel of the Lord went down into the pool at certain times and stirred the water, and that the first person to step in afterward was cured of any disease. Neither addition appears in the earliest manuscripts, including P66, P75, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (as reported), and the wording of verse 4 varies greatly among the manuscripts that have it. The Westcott–Hort text does not include them.
- e (5:4) The verse number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. See the note on 5:3.
- f (5:9) Sabbath: from Hebrew *shabbat*, "rest" or "ceasing," the seventh day of the week, from sunset Friday to sunset Saturday, on which work was forbidden (Exod 20:8–11). Carrying a load from one place to another was counted as work (compare Jer 17:21–22).
- g (5:27) Or "because he is a son of man," that is, a human being; the Greek has no article. Compare Dan 7:13–14.
- h (5:31) True: that is, valid as legal evidence. The Law required two or three witnesses (Deut 19:15; compare 8:13–18).
- i (5:39) Or, as a command, "Pore over the Scriptures."
- j (5:44) The only God: some early witnesses, including P66, P75 and Vaticanus (as reported), read "the only one." The Westcott–Hort text prints "God" in brackets.

Chapter 6

1 Afterward Jesus went away to the far side of the Sea of Galilee, that
is, the Sea of Tiberias.[a] 2 A great crowd kept following him, because
they were watching the signs he did on the sick. 3 Jesus climbed
the hill and was sitting there with his disciples. 4 It was close to the
Passover, the Jewish festival. 5 Lifting his eyes and seeing that a great
crowd was coming toward him, Jesus says to Philip, "Where shall we
buy bread, so that these people may eat?" 6 He said this to test him,
for he himself knew what he was going to do. 7 Philip answered him,
"Two hundred days' wages[b] would not buy bread enough for each
of them to have a mouthful." 8 One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon
Peter's brother, says to him, 9 "There is a boy here with five barley
loaves and two small fish. Yet what use are they for such a crowd?"
10 Jesus said, "Have the people recline." There was much grass in the
place. So the men reclined, about five thousand in number. 11 Then
Jesus took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed
them to those who were reclining; so also with the fish, as much
as they wanted. 12 And when they were filled, he tells his disciples,
"Gather up the pieces left over, so that nothing goes to waste." 13 So
they gathered them up, and from the five barley loaves they filled
twelve baskets with pieces left over by those who had eaten. 14 Seeing
the sign he had done, the people said, "This must surely be the
Prophet who was to come into the world!" 15 Then Jesus, aware that
they were about to come and seize him to make him king, withdrew
again to the mountain by himself.

16 When evening came, his disciples went down to the sea, 17 got into
a boat and started across the sea toward Capernaum. It was already
dark, and Jesus had not yet joined them. 18 The sea was being whipped
up by a strong wind. 19 After they had rowed about three or four miles,[c]
they saw Jesus walking on the sea, coming near the boat, and they
were frightened. 20 But he says to them, "It is I;[d] do not be afraid." 21
Then they were glad to take him into the boat, and immediately the
boat reached the shore they were heading for.

22 The next day the crowd that was still on the far side of the sea
noticed that there had been just one small boat there, and that Jesus

had not got into it with his disciples. His disciples had gone off by themselves. 23 Other boats, however, came from Tiberias near the place where they had eaten the bread after the Lord gave thanks.[e] 24 When the crowd realized that Jesus was not there, and his disciples were gone as well, they boarded the small boats themselves and came to Capernaum searching for Jesus. 25 And when they found him on the other side of the sea, they said to him, "Rabbi, when did you get here?" 26 Jesus answered them, "Amen, amen, I tell you, it is not because you saw signs that you seek me, but because you ate of the loaves and were filled. 27 Do not labor for food that spoils, but for food that remains for eternal life, which the Son of Man will give you, because God the Father has placed his seal on him." 28 So they asked him, "What should we be doing, so as to do God's works?" 29 Jesus answered, "The work God asks of you is this: believe in the one he sent." 30 They said to him, "What sign, then, will you do, so we may see and put our faith in you? What are you going to accomplish? 31 Our ancestors ate the manna[f] in the wilderness, as it is written, 'He gave them bread out of heaven to eat.'"[g] 32 Jesus then said to them, "Amen, amen, I tell you, it was not Moses who gave you the bread out of heaven; my Father is giving you the true bread out of heaven. 33 For the bread of God is the one who comes down out of heaven and gives life to the world." 34 "Sir," they said to him, "always give us this bread." 35 Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life.[h] Whoever comes to me will never go hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty again. 36 But I told you that you have seen me and still you do not believe. 37 All those the Father gives me will come to me, and I will never turn away anyone who comes to me. 38 For I have come down from heaven not to do my own will but the will of the one who sent me. 39 And the will of him who sent me is this, that of all he has given me I lose none, but raise it to life on the last day. 40 For this is the will of my Father, that everyone who looks to the Son and believes in him should have eternal life; and I will raise him up on the last day." 41 Then the Jews began to grumble about him because he said, "I am the bread that came down out of heaven." 42 They were saying, "Is this not Jesus, Joseph's son, whose father and mother we know? How can

he now say, ‘I have come down out of heaven’?” 43 Jesus answered
them, “Stop grumbling among yourselves. 44 No one can come to me
unless the Father who sent me draws him; and I will raise him up
on the last day. 45 It is written in the Prophets, ‘And they will all be
taught by God.’[i] Everyone who has heard from the Father and has
learned comes to me. 46 Not that anyone has seen the Father, except
the one who is from God; he has seen the Father. 47 Amen, amen, I tell
you, whoever believes[j] has eternal life. 48 I am the bread of life. 49 Your
ancestors ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. 50 This is
the bread that comes down from heaven, so that a person may eat it
and never die. 51 I am the living bread that came down out of heaven.
If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever. And the bread that I
will give for the life of the world is my flesh.”
52 The Jews then began to argue sharply with one another, saying,
“How can this man give us his flesh to eat?” 53 Jesus said to them,
“Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man
and drink his blood, you do not have life within you. 54 Whoever feeds
on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him
up on the last day. 55 For my flesh is food indeed, and my blood is
drink indeed. 56 The one who feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood
remains in me, and I remain in him. 57 The living Father sent me, and I
live because of the Father. In the same way, the person who feeds on
me will live because of me. 58 This is the bread that came down out of
heaven, not like the bread the ancestors ate and died. Whoever feeds
on this bread will live forever.” 59 He said these things while teaching
in a synagogue at Capernaum.
60 When they heard this, many of his disciples said, “This is a hard
saying. Who can listen to it?” 61 Jesus was aware that his disciples
were complaining about this, and he said to them, “Does this cause
you to stumble? 62 What if you were to see the Son of Man ascend to
the place where he was before? 63 The Spirit gives life; the flesh is no
help at all. The words I have spoken to you are spirit, and they are
life. 64 Yet some of you do not believe.” For from the start Jesus knew
which of them did not believe and who would betray him. 65 And he

said, “That is why I told you that no one can come to me unless it has been granted him by the Father.”

66 From that point many of his disciples drew back and would no longer go about with him. 67 Jesus then asked the Twelve, “And you, do you also want to leave?” 68 “Lord,” Simon Peter answered, “to whom would we go? It is you who have words of eternal life; 69 and we for our part have believed and know that you are the Holy One of God.”[k] 70 “Was it not I who chose you Twelve?” Jesus answered them. “Yet one of you is a devil.” 71 He was speaking of Judas son of Simon Iscariot,[l] who, though he was one of the Twelve, was going to hand him over.

Notes

- a (6:1) Sea of Tiberias: another name for the Sea of Galilee, from the city of Tiberias on its western shore, founded by Herod Antipas about AD 20 and named in honor of the emperor Tiberius.
- b (6:7) Two hundred days’ wages: literally “two hundred denarii.” A denarius was a silver coin, the usual day’s wage for a laborer (Matt 20:2), so the sum is about eight months’ wages.
- c (6:19) Three or four miles: literally “twenty-five or thirty stadia.” A stadion was about 607 feet (185 m), so the distance is about 3–3½ miles (5–6 km).
- d (6:20) It is I: literally “I am” (Greek *egō eimi*), the ordinary way of saying “It is I,” but in John it may also echo God’s self-designation in the Greek Old Testament (Exod 3:14; Isa 41:4; 43:10, 25). In John Jesus uses *egō eimi* both absolutely (here; 8:24, 28, 58; 13:19; 18:5–8) and with a predicate in seven sayings: “I am the bread of life” (6:35), “the light of the world” (8:12), “the door” (10:7, 9), “the good shepherd” (10:11, 14), “the resurrection and the life” (11:25), “the way, the truth, and the life” (14:6), and “the true vine” (15:1).
- e (6:23) After the Lord gave thanks: a few Western witnesses, including Codex Bezae, omit these words.
- f (6:31) Manna: the food God provided for Israel in the wilderness (Exod 16). Exod 16:15 explains the name by the question *man hu*, “What is it?”
- g (6:31) Compare Ps 78:24; Exod 16:4, 15; Neh 9:15.
- h (6:35) I am the bread of life: the first of the seven “I am” sayings with a predicate; see the note on 6:20.
- i (6:45) Isa 54:13.
- j (6:47) Whoever believes: many later manuscripts add “in me.”
- k (6:69) The Holy One of God: so the earliest manuscripts and the Westcott–Hort text. Later manuscripts read “the Messiah, the Son of the living God” or similar (compare Matt 16:16).

- l (6:71) Iscariot: probably from Hebrew *ish Qeriyyot*, “man of Kerioth,” a town in Judea (Josh 15:25), though other explanations have been proposed. *Judas* is the Greek form of *Judah*, “praised” (Gen 29:35).

Chapter 7

1 After this Jesus moved about in Galilee; he chose not to go about in
Judea, since the Jews were seeking to kill him. 2 But the Jewish festival
of Booths[a] was near. 3 So his brothers told him, “Leave here and go
into Judea, so that your disciples can see the works you do. 4 No one
who wants to be widely known keeps his doings hidden. Since you do
such things, display yourself to the world.” 5 For not even his brothers
believed in him. 6 Jesus therefore says to them, “My time has not yet
arrived, but for you any time will do. 7 The world cannot hate you,
but me it hates, because I testify against it that its works are evil. 8 Go
on up to the feast, all of you. I am not yet[b] going up to this feast, for
my time is not yet complete.” 9 Having told them this, he stayed on
in Galilee.
10 But once his brothers had gone up to the festival, then he too went
up, not openly but as it were in secret. 11 Meanwhile at the feast the
Jews kept searching for him and asking, “Where can he be?” 12 The
crowds were full of whispered talk about him. “He is a good man,”
some said; others said, “Not so; he deceives the people.” 13 Yet for fear
of the Jews nobody would speak openly about him.
14 About the middle of the feast Jesus went up to the temple and
taught. 15 The Jews were astonished and said, “How does this man
know letters, when he has never studied?”[c] 16 Jesus answered them,
“What I teach is not mine; it belongs to the one who sent me. 17 If
anyone resolves to do his will, he will come to know whether my
teaching is from God or whether I speak on my own authority. 18 The
one who speaks on his own authority seeks glory for himself; but the
one who seeks the glory of him who sent him is truthful, and there is
no wrongdoing in him. 19 Did Moses not give you the Law? Yet none
of you obeys it. Why do you want to kill me?” 20 “You are possessed
by a demon!” the crowd answered. “Who wants to kill you?” 21 Jesus
answered them, “I did a single work, and you all wonder at it. 22 Moses
gave you circumcision for this reason[d] (though it did not originate

with Moses but with the fathers),[e] and on the Sabbath you circumcise
a male. 23 If a man receives circumcision on the Sabbath so that the
Law of Moses may not be broken, are you angry with me because
I made a whole man well on the Sabbath? 24 Stop judging by appear-
ances; judge with right judgment."
25 Some of the people of Jerusalem were therefore saying, "Is this not
the man they are seeking to kill? 26 And look, he speaks boldly, and
they say nothing to him. Can it be that the rulers really know that
this is the Messiah? 27 Yet we know where this man comes from; but
when the Messiah comes, no one will know where he is from." 28 So as
he taught in the temple courts Jesus called out loudly, "So you know
me, and you know my origin? Yet it was not on my own initiative
that I came; the one who sent me is genuine, and him you do not
know. 29 I know him, because I am from him, and he sent me." 30 So
they tried to arrest him, yet no one laid a hand on him, because his
hour had not yet come. 31 Many in the crowd, however, put their faith
in him. They said, "Will the Messiah, when he comes, perform more
signs than this man has performed?"
32 The Pharisees overheard the crowd muttering these things about
him. Then the chief priests and Pharisees dispatched temple guards[f]
to arrest him. 33 Jesus then said, "Only a little while longer am I with
you, and then I go to the one who sent me. 34 You will look for me but
will not find me, and you cannot come to where I will be." 35 The Jews
then asked among themselves, "Where is this fellow about to go, that
we will not be able to find him? Surely he does not mean to go to
the Dispersion[g] among the Greeks and teach Greeks? 36 What is this
saying of his, 'You will seek me and not find me,' and, 'Where I am,
you cannot come'?"
37 On the last day of the festival, the great day, Jesus stood and cried
out, "If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink. 38 Whoever
believes in me, as the Scripture has said, 'Rivers of living water will
flow from within him.'"[h] 39 He said this about the Spirit, whom those
who believed in him would receive. The Spirit had not yet been given,[i]
because Jesus had not yet been glorified.

40 On hearing these words, some of the crowd said, “This really is
the Prophet.” 41 Others said, “This is the Messiah.” But some said,
“What? Is the Messiah to come out of Galilee? 42 Has the Scripture not
said that the Messiah comes from the offspring of David,[j] and from
Bethlehem,[k] the village where David was?” 43 So a division arose in
the crowd because of him. 44 Some of them wanted to seize him, but
no one laid hands on him.
45 The officers then went back to the chief priests and Pharisees,
who said to them, “Why have you not brought him?” 46 The officers
answered, “Never has anyone spoken the way this man speaks!” 47
The Pharisees answered them, “Have you been taken in as well? 48 Has
any of the rulers believed in him, or any of the Pharisees? 49 But this
rabble that does not know the Law, they are accursed.” 50 Nicodemus,
who had come to him earlier and was one of them, says to them, 51
“Does our Law condemn a man without first hearing from him and
learning what he is doing?” 52 They replied, “Are you from Galilee
as well? Look into it, and you will find that no prophet comes from
Galilee.”[l] 53 [[[m]Then they went each to his own house.

Notes

- a (7:2) Booths: Greek *skēnopēgia*, “tent-pitching,” the festival of Booths or Tabernacles (Hebrew *Sukkot*), held for seven days in the autumn (Lev 23:33–43), with an eighth day of solemn assembly (7:37).
- b (7:8) Not yet: so P66, P75, Vaticanus (as reported) and the Westcott–Hort text. Sinaiticus, Codex Bezae and some other witnesses read “I am not going up.”
- c (7:15) Know letters: that is, have learning, especially in the Scriptures, without having studied under a rabbi.
- d (7:22) For this reason: the Greek phrase may instead go with the end of 7:21: “and you all wonder at it for this reason.”
- e (7:22) Circumcision was commanded to Abraham (Gen 17:10–12) before it was included in the Law of Moses (Lev 12:3). Since a male child was to be circumcised on the eighth day, the rite was performed even when that day fell on a Sabbath.
- f (7:32) Officers: Greek *hypēretai*, the temple police under the authority of the chief priests.
- g (7:35) The Dispersion: Greek *diaspora*, the Jewish communities living outside the land of Israel.
- h (7:38) The source of the quotation is uncertain; compare Isa 44:3; 55:1; 58:11; Ezek 47:1–12; Zech 14:8. *From within him* is literally “out of his belly.” The punctuation

is also disputed: some join “whoever believes in me” to 7:37 (“let him come to me and drink, whoever believes in me”), so that the rivers flow from within Jesus.

- i (7:39) As yet there was no Spirit: literally “the Spirit was not yet,” that is, had not yet been given. So the Westcott–Hort text with P66 (first hand), P75 and Sinaiticus (as reported); many manuscripts add “given,” and Vaticanus and others reportedly read “the Holy Spirit was not yet given.”
- j (7:42) Compare 2 Sam 7:12; Ps 89:3–4; Mic 5:2. *David* may mean “beloved.”
- k (7:42) Bethlehem: “house of bread.”
- l (7:52) P66 and some later witnesses are reported to read “the Prophet,” that is, the expected prophet like Moses.
- m (7:53) The account of the woman caught in adultery (7:53–8:11) is placed in double brackets because it is almost certainly not part of the original Gospel. It is absent from the earliest Greek manuscripts, including P66 and P75 (about AD 200), Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (fourth century), and probably from Alexandrinus and Ephraemi (which are defective here, but whose missing leaves are too short to have held it); from the earliest Syriac and Coptic versions and many Old Latin manuscripts; and no Greek writer comments on it before the twelfth century. Its earliest Greek witness is Codex Bezae (D, fifth century); it is found in the great majority of later manuscripts and in the Latin Vulgate, and was known to some Western writers such as Ambrose and Augustine, and in a related form perhaps to Papias and the *Didascalia* (third century). In manuscripts that include it, it appears in different places: most often after 7:52, but in some after 7:36, 7:44, or 21:25, and in one group (family 13) after Luke 21:38. Many manuscripts that place it here mark it with asterisks or obeli as doubtful, and its text varies more than any other passage in the Gospels. Its vocabulary and style are closer to Luke than to John. Most scholars regard it as an authentic early tradition about Jesus that circulated independently and was later inserted into the Gospels. Westcott and Hort printed it in double brackets after the end of John; it is placed here, at its traditional position, so as to keep the familiar verse numbering.

Chapter 8

1 But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives.

2 At daybreak he came back into the temple. All the people came to
him, and he sat down and began to teach them. 3 The scribes and the
Pharisees bring a woman who had been caught in adultery, and after
making her stand in the middle, 4 and they say to him, “Teacher, this
woman was caught in the act, committing adultery. 5 Now in the Law
Moses commanded us to stone such women.[a] So what do you say?” 6
They said this to trap him, so that they would have a charge to bring
against him. But Jesus bent down and wrote on the ground with his

finger. 7 And as they persisted in asking him, he stood up straight and
told them, “The one among you who is sinless, let him throw the first
stone at her.” 8 And again he bent down and went on writing on the
ground. 9 When they heard this, they went out one by one, beginning
with the elders, and he was left alone with the woman standing there
in the middle. 10 Then Jesus stood up and asked her, “Woman, where
have they gone? Has nobody condemned you?” 11 She answered, “No
one, sir.” Jesus said, “I do not condemn you either. Go now, and do not
sin again.”]]
12 Jesus spoke to them again, saying, “I am the light of the world.[b]
Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness but will have the
light that gives life.” 13 The Pharisees objected, “You are testifying
about yourself, so your testimony is not valid.” 14 “Though I bear
witness concerning myself,” Jesus answered them, “my witness holds
true, since I know from where I came and to where I go. You, though,
know neither my origin nor my destination. 15 You judge according
to the flesh;[c] I pass judgment on nobody. 16 Yet even if I do judge, my
judgment is true, because I am not alone; it is I and the Father who
sent me. 17 In your own Law it is written that the testimony of two
persons is valid.[d] 18 I am one who testifies about myself, and the Father
who sent me testifies about me.” 19 Then they said to him, “Where is
your Father?” Jesus answered, “You know neither me nor my Father.
If you knew me, you would know my Father as well.” 20 These words
he spoke in the treasury[e] while he taught in the temple; and no one
seized him, because his hour had not yet come.
21 He spoke to them once more: “I am going away. You will search for
me, and you will die in your sin. You are not able to come where I
am going.” 22 At this the Jews said, “He will not kill himself, will he?
Is that why he says, ‘You are not able to come where I am going’?”
23 He said to them, “You are from below; I am from above. You are of
this world; I am not of this world. 24 So I told you that you would die
in your sins; for unless you believe that I am he,[f] you will die in your
sins.” 25 Then they said to him, “Who are you?” Jesus said to them,
“Just what I have been telling you from the beginning.[g] 26 There is
much I could say about you and much I could judge; but the one who

sent me is true, and what I heard from him is what I tell the world."
27 They did not grasp that he was talking to them of the Father. 28 So
Jesus said, "When you have lifted up the Son of Man, then you will
know that I am he, and that I do nothing on my own, but speak just
as the Father taught me. 29 The one who sent me stays with me; he has
not left me on my own, for I always do the things that please him." 30
As he was saying these things, many believed in him.
31 Then Jesus said to the Jews who had put their faith in him, "If
you remain in my word, you are my disciples indeed; 32 and you will
know the truth, and the truth will set you free." 33 They answered him,
"We are Abraham's offspring[h] and have never been slaves to anyone.
How can you say, 'You will become free'?" 34 Jesus answered them,
"Amen, amen, I tell you, everyone who commits sin is a slave of sin.[i] 35
The slave does not remain in the household forever; the son remains
forever. 36 If therefore the Son makes you free, you will truly be free.
37 I know that you are Abraham's offspring; yet you seek to kill me,
because my word finds no room in you. 38 I speak of what I have seen
with the Father; and you, then, do what you have heard from the
father."[j] 39 They answered him, "Our father is Abraham." Jesus says to
them, "If you are children of Abraham, do the works of Abraham.[k] 40
Yet now you are trying to kill me, a man who told you the truth that
I heard from God. Abraham did nothing like that. 41 You are doing the
works of your father." They said to him, "We were not born of sexual
immorality. We have one Father, God himself." 42 Jesus said to them,
"If God were your Father, you would love me, for I came out from
God and have arrived here. I have not come on my own; he sent me.
43 Why is my language not clear to you? It is because you are unable
to listen to my message. 44 You come from your father the devil, and
you are set on doing what your father desires. From the beginning
he was a murderer, and he has not stood in the truth, for truth is not
in him. When he speaks a lie, he is speaking out of his own nature,
for he is a liar and the father of lies.[l] 45 But because I speak the truth,
you do not believe me. 46 Which of you convicts me of sin? If I speak
the truth, why do you not believe me? 47 Whoever is of God hears the
words of God. The reason you do not hear is that you are not of God."

48 “Are we not right,” the Jews replied, “when we say you are a
Samaritan and demon-possessed?” 49 Jesus answered, “I do not have a
demon; I honor my Father, and you dishonor me. 50 I do not seek my
own glory; there is one who seeks it, and he judges. 51 Amen, amen,
I tell you, if anyone keeps my word, he will never see death.” 52 The
Jews said to him, “Now we know that you have a demon! Abraham
died, and so did the prophets; and you say, ‘If anyone keeps my word,
he will never taste death.’ 53 Are you greater than our father Abraham,
who died? The prophets died too! Who do you make yourself out to
be?” 54 Jesus answered, “If I glorify myself, my glory is nothing. It is
my Father who glorifies me, of whom you say, ‘He is our God.’ 55 You
have never known him, but I do know him. Were I to say I do not
know him, I would be a liar, as you are. But I know him, and his word
I keep. 56 Abraham your father was overjoyed at the thought of seeing
my day; and he did see it, and rejoiced.” 57 So the Jews said to him, “You
are not yet fifty years old, and you have seen Abraham?”[m] 58 Jesus said
to them, “Amen, amen, I tell you, before Abraham came to be, I am.”[n]
59 So they picked up stones to throw at him; but Jesus hid himself and
went out of the temple.

Notes

- a (8:5) Lev 20:10 and Deut 22:22 prescribe death for both the man and the woman; Deut 22:23–24 specifies stoning for a betrothed woman and the man.
- b (8:12) I am the light of the world: the second of the “I am” sayings with a predicate (see the note on 6:20). Lamps were lit in the temple’s Court of the Women during the festival of Booths.
- c (8:15) According to the flesh: that is, by human standards.
- d (8:17) Compare Deut 17:6; 19:15.
- e (8:20) The treasury: probably the area of the Court of the Women where the offering chests stood (compare Mark 12:41).
- f (8:24) That I am he: literally “that I am” (Greek *egō eimi*), used absolutely; compare Isa 43:10 (Greek Old Testament), “that you may know and believe … that I am.” See the note on 6:20; also 8:28, 58; 13:19.
- g (8:25) The Greek of Jesus’ answer (*tēn archēn ho ti kai lalō hymin*) is notoriously difficult. Other possible renderings include “Why do I speak to you at all?” and “I am from the beginning what I am telling you.” P66 (as reported) adds “I told you” at the beginning.
- h (8:33) Offspring: literally “seed.”
- i (8:34) Of sin: Codex Bezae and a few other witnesses omit these words.

- j (8:38) From the father: many later manuscripts read “from your father,” which makes clear that the devil is meant (8:44); others read “I speak of what I have seen with my Father.” Without the pronoun, the sentence may also be a command: “and you, then, do what you have heard from the Father.”
- k (8:39) If you are … do: some manuscripts read “If you were … you would do.”
- l (8:44) Father of lies: or “the father of the liar,” or “a liar, and so was his father”; the Greek is ambiguous.
- m (8:57) Seen Abraham: P75, Sinaiticus (first hand) and a few other witnesses are reported to read “and Abraham has seen you?”
- n (8:58) I am: Greek *egō eimi*, used absolutely, without a predicate. Contrasted with Abraham’s “coming to be,” the phrase claims an existence before Abraham and recalls God’s self-naming in Exod 3:14 (“I am who I am”; the Greek Old Testament has *egō eimi ho ōn*) and Isa 43:10–13. The response in 8:59 shows that the hearers took it as blasphemy. See the note on 6:20.

Chapter 9

1 As he went along, he saw a man blind from his birth. 2 His disciples
asked him, “Rabbi, whose sin caused him to be born blind, this man’s
or his parents’?” 3 Jesus answered, “Neither he nor his parents sinned;
it happened so that the works of God might be put on display in him.
4 We[a] have to do the work of the one who sent me while it is still day.
Night is coming, and then no one can work. 5 While I am in the world,
I am the world’s light.” 6 Having said this, he spat on the ground, made
some mud with the spit, and put the mud on the man’s eyes, 7 and
told him, “Go and wash in the pool of Siloam” (a name that means
“Sent”).[b] So the man went off and washed, and came back able to see.
8 His neighbors, and those who had formerly seen him as a beggar,
began saying, “Is this not the fellow who used to sit and beg?” 9 Some
said, “It is he”; others said, “No, but he resembles him.” He kept saying,
“I am the man.” 10 “How then,” they asked him, “did your eyes come to
be opened?” 11 He replied, “That man they call Jesus made some mud
and rubbed it on my eyes and said to me, ‘Off to Siloam, and wash.’ I
went off and washed, and my sight came back.” 12 “Where is he?” they
asked him. He says, “I do not know.”
13 They bring the man who had once been blind to the Pharisees. 14
Now it was a Sabbath on the day Jesus made the mud and opened
his eyes. 15 So the Pharisees also asked him how he came to see. He

told them, “He put mud on my eyes. I washed, and now I see.” 16 Some
of the Pharisees said, “This man does not come from God, because
he does not keep the Sabbath.” Others asked, “How could a sinner do
such signs?” So they were divided. 17 So they turned to the blind man
again: “Since he opened your eyes, what is your opinion of him?” He
said, “He is a prophet.”
18 The Jews did not believe that the man had been blind and then
received his sight, until they sent for his parents, 19 and asked them,
“Is this your son? Do you say he was born blind? Then how can he
see now?” 20 His parents answered, “We know this is our son, and we
know he was born blind. 21 But how he can see now, or who it was
that opened his eyes, we do not know. He is old enough; put your
questions to him. He will speak about himself.” 22 His parents said this
because they were afraid of the Jews; for the Jews had already agreed
that anyone who confessed him as Messiah would be put out of the
synagogue.[c] 23 That is why his parents said, “He is of age; question
him.”
24 So they summoned once more the man who had been blind and said,
“Give glory to God![d] This man, we know, is a sinner.” 25 He answered,
“Whether he is a sinner, I cannot say. One thing I do know: I was
blind, and now I see.” 26 They said to him, “What did he do to you?
How did he open your eyes?” 27 He replied, “I already told you, and
you did not listen. Why do you want to hear it all over again? Do you
also want to become his disciples?” 28 They ridiculed him and said,
“You are his disciple! We are disciples of Moses. 29 We know that God
spoke to Moses, but we do not know where this man comes from.” 30
“Well, here is an astonishing thing!” the man replied. “You have no
idea where he comes from, and yet he has opened my eyes. 31 We
know God does not hear sinners; rather, if anyone is God-fearing and
does what God wills, him God hears. 32 Never since the beginning of
time has anyone heard of someone opening the eyes of a person born
blind. 33 If this man were not from God, he could do nothing at all.” 34
They answered him, “You were born steeped in sin, and you would
teach us?” And they threw him out.

35 Jesus heard that they had thrown him out, and when he found him
he said, “Do you believe in the Son of Man?”[e] 36 He answered, “And
who is he, sir, that I may believe in him?” 37 “You have seen him,” Jesus
said to him. “He is the very one who is talking with you.” 38 He said,
“Lord, I believe,” and he worshiped him.[f] 39 And Jesus said, “I came
into this world for judgment: that the sightless might see, and that
those with sight might be made blind.” 40 Some Pharisees who were
near him heard this and asked him, “We are not blind as well, are
we?” 41 Jesus said to them, “If you were blind, you would have no sin.
But now that you say, ‘We see,’ your sin remains.”

Notes

- a (9:4) We: so the earliest manuscripts and the Westcott–Hort text; many later manuscripts read “I.” Some early witnesses also read “the one who sent us.”
- b (9:7) Siloam: from Hebrew *Shiloach*, “sending” (Isa 8:6), the pool at the south end of the City of David, fed by Hezekiah’s tunnel from the Gihon spring. John interprets the name as “Sent,” pointing to Jesus as the one sent by the Father.
- c (9:22) Put out of the synagogue: Greek *aposynagōgos*, excluded from the synagogue community (also 12:42; 16:2).
- d (9:24) Give glory to God: a solemn charge to tell the truth (compare Josh 7:19).
- e (9:35) The Son of Man: so P66, P75, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus (as reported) and the Westcott–Hort text; many later manuscripts read “the Son of God.”
- f (9:38) P75, Sinaiticus (first hand) and a few other witnesses are reported to omit 9:38 and the opening words of 9:39 (“Jesus said”).

Chapter 10

1 “Amen, amen, I tell you, whoever does not go into the sheepfold
through the gate but climbs in some other way, that man is a thief
and a bandit. 2 But the one who goes in through the gate is shepherd
of the sheep. 3 For him the gatekeeper opens, and the sheep hear his
voice; he calls his own sheep by name and leads them out. 4 When
he has brought out all his own, he walks on ahead of them, and the
sheep follow him, because they know his voice. 5 A stranger they will
never follow; they will flee from him, because they do not know the
voice of strangers.” 6 This was the figure of speech[a] Jesus used with
them, but what he was telling them they did not understand.
7 So Jesus spoke again: “Amen, amen, I tell you, I am the gate[b] for the
sheep. 8 All who came ahead of me are thieves and robbers; but the

sheep paid them no heed. 9 I am the gate. If anyone enters through
me, he will be saved, and will go in and go out and find pasture. 10 The
thief arrives only to steal, to kill, and to destroy. I came so that they
might have life, a full and overflowing life.
11 "I am the good shepherd.[c] The good shepherd lays down his life for
the sheep. 12 The hired hand, who is no shepherd and does not own
the sheep, sees the wolf coming, abandons the sheep, and runs off;
and the wolf snatches them and scatters the flock. 13 He runs because
he works for wages and the sheep are no concern of his. 14 I am the
good shepherd. I know my own, and my own know me, 15 just as the
Father knows me and I know the Father; and I lay down my life for the
sheep. 16 Other sheep too I have, which are not of this fold. These also
I must lead, and they will listen for my voice, and they will become
one flock with one shepherd. 17 For this reason the Father loves me:
because I lay down my life, so that I may take it up again. 18 No one has
taken it[d] from me; I lay it down of my own free will. I have authority
to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again. This charge I
received from my Father."
19 Once more the Jews were divided over these words. 20 Many of them
were saying, "He is demon-possessed and raving. Why pay attention
to him?" 21 Others said, "These are not the sayings of someone pos-
sessed by a demon. Can a demon open the eyes of the blind?"
22 The festival of Dedication[e] was then being held in Jerusalem; it was
the winter season, 23 and Jesus was walking about in the temple, in
Solomon's Colonnade.[f] 24 The Jews therefore surrounded him and kept
saying, "How long are you going to hold us in suspense?[g] If you are
the Messiah, say so openly." 25 Jesus answered them, "I told you, and
you do not believe. The works that I do in my Father's name, these
testify about me. 26 But you do not believe, because you are not among
my sheep. 27 My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they come
after me. 28 I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no
one will snatch them out of my hand. 29 What my Father has given
me is greater than all things,[h] and nobody can snatch anything out
of my Father's hand. 30 I and the Father are one."[i]

31 Again the Jews picked up stones to stone him. 32 Jesus answered, “I
have shown you many good works from the Father. For which one of
them do you want to stone me?” 33 “We are not stoning you for any
good work,” the Jews answered him, “but for blasphemy: you are a
man, and you make yourself God.” 34 Jesus answered them, “Is it not
written in your Law, ‘I said, you are gods’?[j] 35 If he called them gods
to whom the word of God came (and Scripture cannot be set aside),
36 do you say of the one whom the Father consecrated and sent into
the world, ‘You are blaspheming,’ because I said, ‘I am God’s Son’?
37 If I am not doing my Father’s works, do not believe me. 38 But if I
do them, then even if you do not believe me, believe the works, so
that you may know and understand that the Father is in me, and I am
in the Father.” 39 Again they tried to seize him, but he slipped out of
their hands.
40 He went away again across the Jordan to the place where John had
first been baptizing, and he stayed there. 41 Many people came out to
him, saying, “John did no sign at all, yet all that John said of this man
has proved true.” 42 And many believed in him there.

Notes

- a (10:6) Figure of speech: Greek *paroimia*, a proverb or riddle, an illustration with a hidden meaning (also 16:25, 29).
- b (10:7) Gate: or “door.” The third of the “I am” sayings with a predicate (see the note on 6:20). P75 and the Sahidic Coptic version are reported to read “I am the shepherd of the sheep.”
- c (10:11) I am the good shepherd: the fourth “I am” saying with a predicate. *Good* translates Greek *kalos*, which can also mean “noble” or “model.” Compare Ezek 34; Ps 23.
- d (10:18) Has taken it: Greek *ēren*, “took,” the reading of the Westcott–Hort text with P45, Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus (as reported). Most manuscripts read “takes” (*airei*).
- e (10:22) Dedication: Greek *enkainia*, Hebrew *Hanukkah*, the eight-day festival in December commemorating the rededication of the temple by Judas Maccabeus in 164 BC after its profanation by Antiochus IV (1 Macc 4:36–59).
- f (10:23) Solomon’s Colonnade: a covered portico along the east side of the temple court (compare Acts 3:11; 5:12). *Solomon* is related to Hebrew *shalom*, “peace.”
- g (10:24) Hold us in suspense: literally “lift up our soul,” perhaps “keep annoying us.”

- h (10:29) What my Father has given me is greater than all things: so the Westcott–Hort text, following Vaticanus (first hand) and some others, with a neuter relative and adjective. Many manuscripts read instead “My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all.” The manuscript tradition here is complex.
- i (10:30) One: Greek *hen*, neuter, “one thing,” not “one person” (masculine *heis*); unity of action and purpose is in view, which the hearers took as a claim to deity (10:33).
- j (10:34) Ps 82:6.

Chapter 11

1 A certain man was sick, Lazarus[a] of Bethany, the village of Mary[b] and
her sister Martha.[c] 2 (This Mary, whose brother Lazarus was ill, was
the one who anointed the Lord with perfume and wiped his feet dry
with her hair.)[d] 3 The sisters therefore sent a message to him: “Lord,
look, your dear friend is ill.” 4 When Jesus heard this, he said, “This
illness will not lead to death. It is for the glory of God, so that the
Son of God may be glorified through it.” 5 Now Jesus loved Martha
and her sister and Lazarus. 6 Yet when he heard that Lazarus was ill,
he remained where he was for two more days. 7 Only then did he say
to the disciples, “Let us go back to Judea.” 8 “Rabbi,” the disciples say
to him, “just now the Jews were wanting to stone you, and are you
going back there?” 9 Jesus answered, “Does the day not have twelve
hours? A man who walks by day does not stumble, because he sees
by the light of this world. 10 But a man who walks by night stumbles,
because the light is not in him.” 11 He said this, and then he tells them,
“Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep, but I am going there to wake
him.” 12 So the disciples said to him, “Lord, if he has fallen asleep, he
will recover.” 13 Jesus, however, had been speaking of his death, while
they thought he meant ordinary sleep. 14 So then Jesus told them in
plain words, “Lazarus has died, 15 and for your sake I am glad that I
was not there, so that you may believe. But let us go to him.” 16 Then
Thomas, called the Twin,[e] said to his fellow disciples, “Let us go as
well, so that we may die with him.”
17 On his arrival Jesus found that Lazarus had now been four days in
the tomb. 18 Bethany was close to Jerusalem, less than two miles[f] away,
19 and many of the Jews had come to Martha and Mary to console them

over their brother. 20 As soon as Martha heard that Jesus was coming,
she went out to meet him, while Mary stayed seated in the house.
21 Martha said to Jesus, "Lord, had you been here, my brother would
not have died. 22 Even now I know that whatever you ask of God, God
will grant you." 23 Jesus says to her, "Your brother will rise again." 24
Martha says to him, "I know he will rise again in the resurrection on
the last day." 25 Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life.[g]
The one who believes in me will live, even though he dies; 26 and no
one who lives and believes in me will ever die. Do you believe this?"
27 "Yes, Lord," she says to him. "I have believed, and I still believe, that
you are the Messiah, God's Son, who was to come into the world."
28 After saying this she went off and called her sister Mary, telling her
privately, "The Teacher is here and is asking for you." 29 When Mary
heard it, she rose quickly and went to him. 30 Jesus had not yet come
into the village; he was still in the place where Martha had gone out
to him. 31 The Jews who were comforting Mary in the house saw her
stand up quickly and leave. They went after her, thinking that she
was headed for the tomb to weep there. 32 When Mary reached the
place where Jesus was and saw him, she fell at his feet and said, "Lord,
if you had been here, my brother would not have died." 33 When Jesus
saw her weeping, and the Jews who had come with her weeping too,
he was deeply moved in spirit[h] and greatly troubled, 34 and he said,
"Where have you laid him?" They say to him, "Lord, come and see."
35 Jesus wept. 36 So the Jews said, "See how fond of him he was!" 37 But
some of them asked, "He opened the eyes of the blind man. Could he
not have kept this man from dying?"
38 Jesus, once more deeply moved within, comes to the tomb. It was
a cave, and a stone was lying against it. 39 Jesus says, "Take away the
stone." Martha, the dead man's sister, says to him, "Lord, by now there
will be a stench; it has been four days." 40 "Did I not tell you," Jesus says
to her, "that you would see God's glory if you believed?" 41 So they
took away the stone. And Jesus lifted up his eyes and said, "Father, I
thank you for having heard me. 42 I knew you hear me at all times; yet
I spoke on account of the crowd that stands here, that they may come
to believe you sent me." 43 With these words he cried out with a great

voice, “Lazarus, here, outside!” 44 The dead man came out with strips
of linen wrapped around his hands and feet, and a cloth around his
face. Jesus told them, “Untie him and let him go.”
45 So, many of the Jews who had come to visit Mary, and who had
watched what he did, put their faith in him. 46 But some of them went
off to the Pharisees and told them what Jesus had done. 47 The chief
priests and the Pharisees therefore convened the council[i] and said,
“What are we doing? Here is this man working many signs. 48 If we
let him go on like this, everyone will believe in him, and the Romans
will come and take away both our place[j] and our nation.” 49 But one
of them, Caiaphas,[k] who was high priest that year, said to them, “You
know nothing at all, 50 nor do you consider that it is to your advantage
for one man to die on behalf of the people, rather than for the entire
nation to be lost.” 51 It was not from himself that he said this; rather,
as high priest that year he prophesied that Jesus would die on behalf
of the nation, 52 and not for the nation only, but also to gather into
one the scattered children of God. 53 From that day, then, their counsel
was to put him to death.
54 For this reason Jesus no longer walked about in public among the
Jews. He left that place for the country close to the wilderness, to a
town called Ephraim,[l] and stayed there with the disciples.
55 Now the Passover of the Jews was near, and many went up from the
countryside to Jerusalem before the Passover to purify themselves. 56
They searched for Jesus, and as they stood in the temple they asked
one another, “What do you think? Will he not come to the festival at
all?” 57 Now the chief priests and the Pharisees had given orders that
anyone who knew where he was should report it, so that they might
arrest him.

Notes

- a (11:1) Lazarus: a Greek form of Hebrew *Eleazar*, “God has helped.”
- b (11:1) Mary: Greek *Mariam* or *Maria*, from Hebrew *Miryam* (Miriam), a name of uncertain meaning.
- c (11:1) Martha: Aramaic, “lady” or “mistress.”
- d (11:2) The anointing is narrated in 12:1–8; John refers to it here as already known to his readers.

- e (11:16) Thomas ... the Twin: *Thomas* is from Aramaic *toma*, "twin," and Greek *Didymos* also means "twin."
- f (11:18) Less than two miles: literally "about fifteen stadia," about 1¾ miles (2.8 km).
- g (11:25) I am the resurrection and the life: the fifth "I am" saying with a predicate (see the note on 6:20). P45 and a few other witnesses are reported to omit "and the life."
- h (11:33) Deeply moved in spirit: Greek *enebrimēsato*, a strong word that elsewhere expresses indignation or stern rebuke (Mark 1:43; 14:5); here perhaps anger at the power of death, or intense distress. So also in 11:38.
- i (11:47) Council: Greek *synedrion*, the Sanhedrin, the supreme Jewish council in Jerusalem, presided over by the high priest.
- j (11:48) Our place: probably the temple (compare Acts 6:13–14), or perhaps Jerusalem or the council's position.
- k (11:49) Caiaphas: Joseph Caiaphas, high priest AD 18–36, son-in-law of Annas (18:13). *That year* means "in that fateful year."
- l (11:54) Ephraim: perhaps et-Taiyibeh, about 12 miles (19 km) northeast of Jerusalem. The name means "doubly fruitful" (Gen 41:52).

Chapter 12

1 Six days before the Passover Jesus came to Bethany, where Lazarus
was, whom Jesus had raised from the dead. 2 There they gave a dinner
for him. Martha was serving, and Lazarus was one of those reclining
at table with him. 3 Then Mary took a pound[a] of very costly perfume,
pure nard,[b] anointed Jesus' feet, and wiped his feet with her hair; and
the house was filled with the fragrance of the perfume. 4 But Judas
Iscariot, one of his disciples, who was about to betray him, says, 5
"Why was this ointment not sold for three hundred days' wages,[c] and
the proceeds given to the poor?" 6 He said this not because he cared
about the poor, but because he was a thief; he kept the money bag
and used to help himself to what was put in it. 7 So Jesus said, "Let her
alone; she was to keep it for the day of my burial.[d] 8 For you always
have the poor with you, but you do not always have me."
9 Then a large crowd of the Jews found out he was there, and they
came, not for Jesus' sake alone, but to see Lazarus too, whom he had
raised from the dead. 10 The chief priests, however, resolved to kill
Lazarus also, 11 because many of the Jews were leaving them for his
sake and putting their faith in Jesus.

12 On the following day the large crowd who had come up for the
feast, hearing that Jesus was on his way into Jerusalem, 13 So they
took branches of palm trees and went out to meet him, shouting,
"Hosanna![e] Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord,[f] even
the King of Israel!" 14 Jesus came upon a young donkey and seated
himself on it, just as Scripture says, 15 "Fear not, daughter of Zion;
look, your king comes, sitting on the colt of a donkey."[g] 16 His disciples
did not grasp this at first. Only after Jesus had been glorified did they
remember that these things were written about him, and that these
were the things people had done to him. 17 The crowd that had been
with him when he called Lazarus out of the tomb and raised him from
the dead kept bearing witness. 18 That was the reason the crowd went
to meet him: they had heard that he had performed this sign. 19 So
the Pharisees said to one another, "You see, you are getting nowhere.
Look, the world has gone after him!"
20 Among those who went up to worship at the festival were some
Greeks. 21 They approached Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee,
and made a request of him: "Sir, we wish to see Jesus." 22 Philip goes
and tells Andrew; Andrew and Philip go and tell Jesus. 23 And Jesus
answers them, "The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified.
24 Amen, amen, I tell you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth
and dies, it remains a single grain; but if it dies, it bears much fruit.
25 The one who loves his life is losing it, and the one who hates his
life in this world will guard it to life eternal. 26 Whoever serves me
must follow me, and my servant will be wherever I am. The Father
will honor anyone who serves me.
27 "Now my soul is in turmoil. What am I to say? 'Father, rescue me
from this hour'? No, this is the very reason I came to this hour. 28
Father, bring glory to your name." Then a voice came from heaven:
"I have glorified it, and I will glorify it again." 29 The crowd standing
there heard it and said it had thundered. Others said, "An angel has
spoken to him." 30 Jesus replied, "It was not on my account that this
voice came, but on yours. 31 Now is the judgment of this world; now
the ruler of this world will be driven out. 32 And I, when I am lifted
up from the earth, will draw all people to myself."[h] 33 He said this

to indicate by what kind of death he was going to die. 34 The crowd answered him, "We have heard out of the Law that the Messiah abides forever.[i] So how do you say the Son of Man has to be lifted up? Who is he, this Son of Man?" 35 Jesus then said to them, "For only a short time more the light is with you. Keep walking as long as you have the light, lest darkness seize you; the one who walks in darkness has no idea where he goes. 36 Believe in the light while you have it, so that you may become people of the light." When Jesus had said these things, he left and hid from them.

37 But for all the signs he had done in their sight, they did not believe in him, 38 This happened so that the word spoken by the prophet Isaiah would be fulfilled: "Lord, who has believed what we reported? To whom has the Lord's mighty arm been revealed?"[j] 39 That is why they could not believe; for again Isaiah said, 40 "He has made their eyes blind and their heart hard, lest they see with the eyes and grasp with the heart and turn back, and I heal them."[k] 41 Isaiah said these things because[l] he saw his glory and spoke about him. 42 Even so, many of the leaders believed in him. But because of the Pharisees they would not admit it openly, for fear of being expelled from the synagogue, 43 They loved the glory people give more than the glory God gives.

44 Then Jesus cried out and said, "Whoever believes in me believes not in me but in the one who sent me. 45 And whoever sees me sees the one who sent me. 46 I, a light, have come into the world, that whoever believes in me may not be left in the dark. 47 If someone hears my sayings and fails to keep them, it is not I who judge him. I came not to condemn the world but to save it. 48 Whoever sets me aside and will not accept my sayings has one who judges him: the very word I have spoken will be his judge on the last day. 49 I did not speak from myself; the Father who sent me gave me his own command about what I should say and how I should speak. 50 And I know that his command is life eternal. So the things I speak, I speak as the Father has said them to me."

Notes

- a (12:3) A pound: literally "a litra," the Roman pound (Latin *libra*), about 12 ounces (327 g).

- b (12:3) Pure nard: Greek *nardos pistikē*, an aromatic oil made from a plant of the Himalayas; the meaning of *pistikē* is uncertain (perhaps "genuine" or a place name).
- c (12:5) Three hundred days' wages: literally "three hundred denarii," about a year's wages for a laborer. See the note on 6:7.
- d (12:7) She was to keep it for the day of my burial: the Greek is difficult. Many later manuscripts read "she has kept it for the day of my burial." Others take it as "Let her keep it for the day of my burial."
- e (12:13) Hosanna: a Greek transliteration of Hebrew *hoshiah na*, "Save, we pray!" (Ps 118:25), which had become a shout of praise.
- f (12:13) Ps 118:26. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- g (12:15) Zech 9:9, abbreviated; *do not be afraid* may come from Isa 40:9 or Zeph 3:16. *Zion* is the hill of Jerusalem, and by extension the city and its people.
- h (12:32) All people: P66 (as reported), Sinaiticus (first hand), Codex Bezae and the Latin versions read "all things."
- i (12:34) Compare Ps 89:36–37; Isa 9:7; Ezek 37:25; Dan 7:14. *The Law* here means the Scriptures generally.
- j (12:38) Isa 53:1, following the Greek Old Testament, which adds the opening "Lord" (addressed to God). In the Hebrew text, "the arm of the Lord" is "the arm of Yahweh."
- k (12:40) Isa 6:10, in a form that differs from both the Hebrew and the Greek Old Testament.
- l (12:41) Because: so the Westcott–Hort text with the earliest manuscripts; many later manuscripts read "when." Isaiah's vision of the Lord's glory is in Isa 6:1–5.

Chapter 13

1 It was before the feast of the Passover, and Jesus knew that his hour
had come to pass out of this world to the Father. He had loved his
own who were in the world, and he loved them to the end.[a] 2 During
supper,[b] when the devil had already planted in the heart of Judas son
of Simon Iscariot the resolve to hand him over, 3 Jesus, knowing that
the Father had put everything into his hands, and that he had come
out from God and was going back to God, 4 gets up from the supper,
lays aside his outer garments, takes a towel, and ties it around his
waist. 5 After that, he poured water into a basin and began washing
the disciples' feet, drying them with the towel wrapped around his
waist. 6 So he comes to Simon Peter, who says to him, "Lord, you,
washing my feet?" 7 Jesus replied, "What I do, you do not understand
yet; you will come to know it after these things." 8 Peter says to

him, “Never shall you wash my feet, not ever!” Jesus answered him,
“Unless I wash you, you have no share with me.” 9 Simon Peter says
to him, “Lord, then not only my feet, but my hands and my head as
well!” 10 Jesus says to him, “One who has bathed needs only to wash
his feet;[c] he is clean all over. And you are clean, though not all of you.”
11 He knew his betrayer; that is why he said, “You are not all clean.”
12 After he had washed their feet, put his outer clothing back on, and
returned to his place, he asked them, “Do you understand what I have
just done to you? 13 You call me ‘the Teacher’ and ‘the Lord,’ and you
are right to say it, for so I am. 14 If I then, the Lord and the Teacher,
have washed your feet, you too are bound to wash one another’s feet.
15 I have set you a pattern, so that you also may do as I have done
for you. 16 Amen, amen, I tell you, a slave is not above his master, nor
is a messenger[d] above the one who sent him. 17 Now that you know
these things, blessed are you if you act on them. 18 I am not speaking
of all of you; I know whom I have chosen. But the Scripture must be
fulfilled: ‘The one who eats my bread has raised his heel against me.’[e]
19 I tell you this now, ahead of the event, that once it takes place you
may believe that I am.[f] 20 Amen, amen, I tell you, whoever welcomes
anyone I send welcomes me, and whoever welcomes me welcomes
the one who sent me.”
21 After saying this, Jesus was troubled in spirit, and he testified,
“Amen, amen, I tell you, one of you will betray me.” 22 The disciples
looked at one another, at a loss to know whom he meant. 23 There
was reclining close to Jesus[g] one of his disciples, whom Jesus loved.[h]
24 So Simon Peter motions to him to ask Jesus whom he was speaking
of. 25 Leaning back, then, against Jesus’ chest, that disciple says to
him, “Lord, who is it?” 26 Jesus replied, “I will dip a piece of bread,
and whoever receives it is the one.” Then he dipped the bread and
handed it to Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot. 27 After the morsel, Satan[i]
then entered into him. So Jesus says to him, “What you are doing, do
quickly.” 28 But none of those at table knew why he had said this to
him. 29 Since Judas had charge of the money bag, some supposed that
Jesus was telling him, “Buy what we need for the feast,” or that he

should give something to the poor. 30 So, after receiving the morsel,
he went out at once. And it was night.
31 When he had gone out, Jesus says, "Now has the Son of Man been
glorified, and God has been glorified in him. 32 And God[j] will glorify
him in himself, and without delay. 33 Little children, only a little while
more am I with you. You will seek me; and what I said to the Jews I
say now to you as well: 'Where I go, you are unable to come.' 34 I am
giving you a new commandment: love one another. As I have loved
you, so you are to love one another. 35 By this everyone will recognize
that you are my disciples: if you have love among yourselves."
36 Simon Peter says to him, "Lord, where are you going?" Jesus
answered, "Where I am going you cannot follow me now, but you
will follow later." 37 Peter says to him, "Lord, why can I not follow you
now? I will lay down my life for you." 38 Jesus answered, "You will
give up your life for me? Truly, truly, I say to you, before the rooster
crows, you will have denied me three times.

Notes

- a (13:1) To the end: or "to the uttermost," "completely"; Greek *eis telos* can mean both.
- b (13:2) During supper: so the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus (present participle, as reported); many manuscripts read "when supper was over."
- c (13:10) Needs only to wash his feet: the words "except the feet" (here "only … his feet") are bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; Sinaiticus, some Latin witnesses and some early writers lack them, giving "One who has bathed has no need to wash."
- d (13:16) Messenger: Greek *apostolos*, "one who is sent," the word usually rendered "apostle."
- e (13:18) Ps 41:9 (40:10 Greek). To raise one's heel against someone is to turn on him in treachery.
- f (13:19) That I am: Greek *egō eimi*, perhaps "that I am he"; see the notes on 6:20 and 8:58.
- g (13:23) Close to Jesus: literally "in the bosom of Jesus." At a formal meal the guests reclined on their left side, so that the head of one lay near the chest of the one to his left. Compare 1:18.
- h (13:23) Whom Jesus loved: the first mention of the "beloved disciple," who appears again at 19:26; 20:2; 21:7, 20, and is named as the source of the Gospel at 21:24. He is unnamed in the Gospel; second-century tradition identified him with John the son of Zebedee.

- i (13:27) Satan: from Hebrew *satan*, “adversary, accuser.”
- j (13:32) God: many manuscripts, followed by most modern editions, begin the verse “If God has been glorified in him, God will also …”; the clause is absent from P66, Sinaiticus (first hand), Vaticanus, Ephraemi (first hand) and Bezae (as reported), and from the Westcott–Hort text.

Chapter 14

1 “Do not let your hearts be troubled. You believe in God; believe
also in me.[a] 2 My Father’s house has many dwelling places.[b] Were it
otherwise, would I have said to you that I go to prepare you a place?
[c] 3 And when I have gone and prepared a place for you, I will come
back and bring you to myself, so that you may be where I am. 4 And
where I am going, you know the way.”[d] 5 Thomas says to him, “Lord,
we have no idea where you are going; how can we know the way?” 6
Jesus says to him, “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.[e] Nobody
comes to the Father except through me. 7 If you had known me, you
would have known my Father also.[f] From now on you know him and
have seen him.”
8 Philip says to him, “Lord, show us the Father, and that will be enough
for us.” 9 Jesus says to him, “Have I been among you all this time,
Philip, and still you have not come to know me? Anyone who has
seen me has seen the Father. How is it that you say, ‘Show us the
Father’? 10 Do you not believe that I am in the Father and the Father
in me? The sayings I speak to you are not from myself; the Father,
who abides in me, is doing his own works. 11 Take my word for it
that I am in the Father and the Father in me; or else believe on the
strength of the works themselves. 12 Truly, truly, I say to you, anyone
who believes in me will do the works I do, and will do even greater
ones, because I am going to the Father. 13 Whatever you ask in my
name I will do, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son. 14 If you
ask me[g] for anything in my name, I will do it.
15 “Love me, and you will keep the commands that are mine. 16 And I
will ask the Father, and he will give you another Advocate,[h] to be with
you forever: 17 the Spirit of truth. The world is unable to receive him,
for it does not behold him or recognize him; but you recognize him,
for he abides beside you and is[i] in you. 18 I will not leave you orphans;

I am coming to you. 19 Yet a little while, and the world beholds me no
more; but you behold me. Because I live, you will live as well. 20 On
that day you will know that I am in my Father, and you in me, and I in
you. 21 Whoever holds my commands and keeps them is the one who
loves me. My Father will love the one who loves me, and I will love
him and make myself plain to him." 22 Judas (not Iscariot)[j] says to him,
"Lord, what has happened, that you are going to show yourself to us
and not to the world?" 23 Jesus answered him, "If anyone loves me, he
will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come
to him and make our dwelling with him. 24 The one without love for
me does not keep my sayings; and the word you are hearing is not
my own, but belongs to the Father who sent me.
25 "All this I have told you while still remaining with you. 26 But the
Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name,
he will teach you everything and remind you of everything I have
said to you. 27 Peace I leave you; my peace I give you; I give it not
in the way the world gives. Let your hearts not be shaken, nor be
fearful. 28 You heard what I said to you: 'I go away, and I come to you.'
Had you loved me, you would have been glad that I go to the Father,
for the Father is greater than I. 29 And now I have told you before it
happens, so that when it happens you may believe. 30 I will not say
much more to you, because the ruler of this world is approaching. He
has no power over me;[k] 31 but so that the world may know that I love
the Father, I do just as the Father has commanded me. Rise, let us go
from here.[l]

Notes

- a (14:1) You believe in God; believe also in me: both verbs can be either statements or commands: "Believe in God; believe also in me," or "You believe in God, and you believe in me."
- b (14:2) Dwelling places: Greek *monai*, "places to stay" (the noun from *menō*, "remain, abide," as in 14:23); the older rendering "mansions" is from the Latin *mansiones*.
- c (14:2) Would I have told you ...?: or "If it were not so, I would have told you, for I am going to make ready a place for you." The punctuation and the presence of "for" (in many manuscripts) are uncertain.
- d (14:4) You know the way: many manuscripts read, in effect, "You know where I am going, and you know the way."

- e (14:6) I am the way, and the truth, and the life: the sixth "I am" saying with a predicate (see the note on 6:20).
- f (14:7) You would have known my Father also: P66, Sinaiticus and Bezae (as reported) read, in effect, "If you have come to know me, you will also know my Father."
- g (14:14) Me: so the Westcott–Hort text (in brackets) with P66, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts lack "me."
- h (14:16) Advocate: Greek *paraklētos*, "one called alongside" to help, used of a legal advocate or counselor; also rendered "Helper," "Counselor" or "Comforter," or transliterated "Paraclete." So in 14:26; 15:26; 16:7; and of Jesus in 1 John 2:1.
- i (14:17) Is: so the Westcott–Hort text with P66 (first hand), Vaticanus and Bezae (first hand, as reported); many manuscripts read "will be."
- j (14:22) Judas (not Iscariot): probably the "Judas son of James" of Luke 6:16 and Acts 1:13, perhaps the same as Thaddaeus (Mark 3:18). *Judas* is the Greek form of *Judah*, "praised."
- k (14:30) He has no hold on me: literally "in me he has nothing."
- l (14:31) Rise, let us go from here: the discourse continues through chapters 15–17 before they leave in 18:1; many scholars see here a sign that the farewell discourses were composed in stages.

Chapter 15

1 "I am the true vine,[a] and the vinedresser is my Father. 2 Every branch
in me that yields no fruit he cuts away, and every branch that yields
fruit he prunes clean,[b] that it may yield fruit more abundantly. 3
Already you are clean, by reason of the word I have spoken to you.
4 Abide in me, and I in you. A branch has no power to yield fruit by
itself unless it abides in the vine, and no more have you unless you
abide in me. 5 I am the vine; you are the branches. The one abiding
in me, with me abiding in him, is the one who yields fruit in plenty;
for apart from me you are able to do nothing. 6 If anyone does not
abide in me, he is thrown out like the branch and withers; and such
branches are gathered and tossed into the fire, and they burn. 7 If you
abide in me, and my sayings abide in you, ask for whatever you will,
and it shall come about for you. 8 Herein is my Father glorified: that
you yield fruit in plenty and so prove to be[c] my disciples. 9 Just as
the Father loved me, so I too loved you. Abide in my love. 10 If you
keep my commands, you will abide in my love, as I have kept the
commands of my Father and abide in his love. 11 I have said all this

to you so that my joy may be within you, and your joy brought to fullness.
12 “This is the command that is mine: love one another as I loved you.
13 No one has love greater than this, that a person lay down his life on behalf of his friends. 14 You are friends of mine if you do the things I command you. 15 I no longer call you slaves, since a slave is not let into his master’s plans. You I have called friends, for everything I heard from my Father I have shared with you. 16 It was not you who chose me; I chose you, and I appointed you to go out and yield fruit, fruit that will abide, so that the Father may grant you whatever you ask him in my name. 17 This I command you: love one another.
18 “If the world hates you, know that it hated me before it hated you.
19 Were you of the world, the world would be fond of what is its own. But because you are not of the world, but I chose you out from the world, for this reason the world hates you. 20 Call to mind the word I spoke to you: ‘A slave is not above his master.’[d] Since they persecuted me, they will persecute you also; since they kept my word, they will keep yours as well.[e] 21 But all these things they will do to you for my name’s sake, because the one who sent me they do not know. 22 Had I not come and spoken to them, they would not have sin; but as things are, they have no excuse to cover their sin. 23 Whoever hates me hates my Father as well. 24 If I had not done among them works that no one else had done, they would not be guilty of sin. But now they have seen those works, and they have hated both me and my Father. 25 But this happened to fulfill what is written in their Law: ‘They hated me for no reason.’[f]
26 “When the Advocate[g] comes, whom I will send you from the Father, the Spirit of truth who goes forth from the Father, he will bear witness about me; 27 and you too are witnesses, for you have been with me from the start.

Notes

- a (15:1) I am the true vine: the seventh “I am” saying with a predicate (see the note on 6:20). In the Old Testament Israel is God’s vine or vineyard (Ps 80:8–16; Isa 5:1–7; Jer 2:21).

- b (15:2) Prunes clean: Greek *kathairei*, “cleanses,” a wordplay with *katharoi*, “clean,” in 15:3.
- c (15:8) Prove to be: so the Westcott–Hort text (subjunctive, as reported from Vaticanus and Bezae); many manuscripts read “you will be.”
- d (15:20) See 13:16.
- e (15:20) Since … since: or “If … if.” The second clause may be ironic.
- f (15:25) Ps 35:19; 69:4 (34:19; 68:5 Greek). *Law* here means the Scriptures generally.
- g (15:26) Advocate: Greek *paraklētos*; see the note on 14:16.

Chapter 16

1 “All this I have said to you so that you will not be made to stumble.[a]
2 They will put you out of the synagogues. Indeed, a time is coming
when anyone who kills you will suppose he is offering God an act of
worship. 3 And they will do these things because they have known
neither the Father nor me. 4 But I have told you these things so that,
when their hour arrives, you may remember that I told you of them. I
did not speak of this to you at the beginning, because I was with you.
5 “But now I go to him who sent me, and none of you asks me, ‘Where
are you going?’ 6 Rather, sorrow has filled your hearts because I have
spoken of these things. 7 But it is the truth I tell you: it is to your
advantage that I depart. Unless I depart, the Advocate will not come
to you; if I go, though, I will send him to you. 8 And when he comes,
he will expose the world’s error[b] concerning sin and righteousness
and judgment: 9 concerning sin, because they do not believe in me; 10
concerning righteousness, because I go to the Father and you see me
no longer; 11 concerning judgment, because the ruler of this world has
been judged.
12 “I have yet many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them
now. 13 When he comes, the Spirit of truth, he will guide you into all
the truth;[c] for he will not speak from himself, but will speak whatever
he hears, and he will announce to you the things that are coming.
14 He will bring glory to me, because he will take what is mine and
make it known to you. 15 Everything the Father has belongs to me.
That is why I said that he takes what is mine and makes it known
to you.

16 “A little while, and you no longer see me; and again a little while,
and you will see me.” 17 At this, some of his disciples began to say to
each other, “Whatever is this he says to us, ‘A little while, and you
do not see me, and again a little while, and you will see me,’ and,
‘Because I am going to the Father’?” 18 So they kept asking, “What is
this ‘little while’ he speaks of? We do not know what he means.” 19
Jesus knew they wanted to ask him something, so he said to them,
“Are you discussing with each other what I meant when I said, ‘In a
little while you will not see me, and then in a little while you will see
me’? 20 Truly, truly, I say to you, you will cry and mourn while the
world celebrates. You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will become
joy. 21 A woman in labor suffers, because her hour has arrived. But
when she has delivered the child, she no longer remembers the pain,
in her joy that a human being has been born into the world. 22 So you
also now have grief; but I will see you again, and your hearts will
rejoice, and your joy no one takes from you. 23 On that day you will
not ask me anything. Truly, truly, I say to you, whatever you ask the
Father in my name, he will give you.[d] 24 Until now you have asked
nothing in my name. Ask, and you will receive, so that your joy may
be complete.
25 “I have spoken these things to you in figures of speech.[e] An hour
is coming when I will no longer speak to you in figures, but will tell
you plainly about the Father. 26 On that day you will ask in my name;
and I do not say to you that I will ask the Father on your behalf, 27 for
the Father himself loves you, because you have loved me and have
believed that I came from the Father.[f] 28 From the Father I came out,
and I have come into the world; now once more I leave the world and
make my way to the Father.”
29 His disciples say, “There! Now you are speaking plainly and using
no figure of speech. 30 Now we can see that you know everything and
do not need anyone to ask you questions. Because of this, we believe
that you came from God.” 31 Jesus answered them, “Do you believe
now?[g] 32 See, the hour is coming, and has now come, for you to be
scattered each to his own, leaving me by myself. And yet I am not by
myself, for the Father is with me. 33 I have told you these things so

that in me you may have peace. In the world you have distress; but take courage: I have conquered the world."

Notes

- a (16:1) Made to stumble: Greek *skandalizō*, to cause to fall away from faith.
- b (16:8) Expose the world's error: Greek *elenchō*, "convict, prove wrong, bring to light."
- c (16:13) Into all the truth: some manuscripts, including Sinaiticus and Bezae (as reported), read "in all the truth."
- d (16:23) He will give it to you in my name: so the Westcott–Hort text with P5, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and Ephraemi (as reported); many manuscripts read "whatever you ask the Father in my name, he will give you."
- e (16:25) Figures of speech: Greek *paroimia*, a veiled or enigmatic saying; so in 10:6 and 16:29.
- f (16:27) From the Father: so the Westcott–Hort text with Vaticanus and Bezae (as reported, "from the Father," *para tou patros*); many manuscripts read "from God."
- g (16:31) Do you believe now?: or "Now you believe!"

Chapter 17

1 After Jesus said these things, he looked up to heaven and said,
"Father, the time has come. Give glory to your Son, so that your Son
may give glory to you, 2 since you gave him authority over all flesh,
so that he might give eternal life to all whom you have given him.[a] 3
And eternal life is this: that they know you, the only true God, and
the one you sent, Jesus Christ. 4 On the earth I have brought you
glory, finishing the task you assigned me. 5 So now, Father, glorify me
at your own side with the glory I had at your side before the world
existed.
6 "To those you gave me from the world I have revealed your name.[b]
They belonged to you, and you entrusted them to me, and they have
held fast to your word. 7 They know now that all you have given me
comes from you; 8 for the sayings you gave me I have passed on to
them, and they took them in and knew in truth that I came forth from
you, and they believed that you sent me. 9 It is for them that I make
my request. I do not make it for the world, but for those you have
given me, because they are yours. 10 All that I have is yours, and all
that you have is mine. Through them I have been glorified. 11 I am in
the world no longer, but they remain in the world, while I come to

you. Holy Father, guard them by your name, the name you have given
me,[c] that they may be one as we are one. 12 When I was with them, I
protected them by your name, the name you gave me. I watched over
them, and not one was lost except the one headed for destruction,[d] so
that Scripture would be fulfilled. 13 But now I am coming to you, and
I speak these things while in the world, so that they may have my
joy brought to fullness within themselves. 14 I have given them your
word, and the world hated them, since they are not of the world, as
I am not of the world. 15 My request is not that you take them out of
the world, but that you keep them from the evil one.[e] 16 They are not
of the world, as I am not of the world. 17 Make them holy[f] by the truth;
your word is truth. 18 Just as you sent me into the world, I in turn have
sent them into the world. 19 I set myself apart for their sake, so that
they also may be truly set apart.
20 "Nor do I make request for these alone, but also for those who
believe in me through their word, 21 that all may be one; that as you,
Father, are in me and I in you, they also may be in us,[g] so that the
world may believe that you sent me. 22 The glory that you have given
me I have given to them, that they may be one as we are one, 23 I in
them and you in me, that they may be brought to perfect oneness, so
that the world may come to know that you sent me and loved them
as you loved me. 24 Father, as for what you have given me,[h] I desire
that where I am, they also may be with me, to behold my glory, which
you have given me because you loved me before the foundation of
the world. 25 Father, you who are righteous: though the world did not
know you, I knew you, and these men have come to know that it was
you who sent me. 26 To them I revealed your name, and I will go on
revealing it, so that the love you had for me may be within them, and
I myself within them."

Notes

- a (17:2) All whom you have given him: literally "all that you have given him," a neuter singular collective, as also in 17:24.
- b (17:6) I have revealed your name: literally "I manifested your name," that is, revealed who God is.

- c (17:11) The name you have given me: so the Westcott–Hort text with the earliest manuscripts (the relative pronoun agreeing with "name"); some later manuscripts read "those whom you have given me." So also in 17:12.
- d (17:12) The son of destruction: a Semitic idiom for one destined to perish (compare 2 Thess 2:3), here Judas. The Scripture is probably Ps 41:9, quoted in 13:18.
- e (17:15) From the evil one: or "from evil."
- f (17:17) Make them holy: Greek *hagiason*, "sanctify, consecrate, set apart for God"; the same verb is rendered "consecrate" in 17:19.
- g (17:21) In us: many manuscripts read "one in us."
- h (17:24) What you have given me: see the note on 17:2. Many manuscripts read "those whom you have given me."

Chapter 18

1 After saying these things, Jesus went out with his disciples across the
Kidron ravine,[a] where there was a garden, which he and his disciples
entered. 2 Judas, who was betraying him, also knew the place, for
Jesus had often met there with his disciples. 3 So Judas, having taken
the cohort[b] and some officers from the chief priests and from the
Pharisees, comes there with lanterns and torches and weapons. 4 Then
Jesus, knowing all that was about to befall him, came forward and
says to them, "Whom are you seeking?" 5 They answered him, "Jesus
the Nazarene." He says to them, "I am he."[c] Judas, who was betraying
him, was also standing with them. 6 As soon as he told them, "I am
he," they stepped backward and dropped to the ground. 7 Again then
he asked them, "Whom are you seeking?" And they said, "Jesus the
Nazarene." 8 "I have told you I am he," Jesus replied. "If it is me you
want, then allow these to go their way." 9 This was to fulfill the word
he had spoken, "Of those you have given me I have not lost one."[d] 10
Simon Peter had a sword; he drew it, struck at the slave of the high
priest, and sliced off his right ear. Malchus[e] was the slave's name. 11 So
Jesus said to Peter, "Put the sword into its sheath. The cup the Father
has given me, shall I not drink it?"
12 Then the cohort and its commander[f] and the officers of the Jews
seized Jesus and bound him. 13 They led him first to Annas,[g] for he
was father-in-law of Caiaphas, who was high priest that year. 14 It was
Caiaphas who had counseled the Jews that it was expedient for one
man to die for the people.

15 Simon Peter followed Jesus, along with another disciple. Because
this disciple was an acquaintance of the high priest, he went in with
Jesus into the high priest's courtyard, 16 but Peter was standing by the
door outside. The other disciple, the acquaintance of the high priest,
came out, had a word with the doorkeeper, and brought Peter inside. 17
The servant girl at the door then says to Peter, "You are not one of this
man's disciples too, are you?" He says, "I am not." 18 The slaves and
the officers had lit a charcoal fire, since it was cold, and stood about
it warming themselves; and Peter too stood among them, warming
himself.
19 The high priest therefore asked Jesus about his disciples and what
he taught. 20 Jesus answered him, "I have spoken openly to the world.
I always taught in synagogue and in the temple, where all the Jews
come together, and in secret I said nothing. 21 Why do you ask me?
Ask the people who heard what I told them. They know what I said." 22
After he said this, one of the officers who was standing there slapped
Jesus and said, "Is this how you respond to the high priest?" 23 Jesus
answered him, "If I spoke wrongly, testify to the wrong; but if rightly,
why do you strike me?" 24 Annas then sent him bound to Caiaphas
the high priest.
25 Simon Peter, meanwhile, stood warming himself. They said to him,
"Surely you are not another of his disciples?" He denied it: "I am not."
26 A slave of the high priest, kinsman to the one whose ear Peter had
cut off, says, "Didn't I see you in the garden, with him?" 27 Again Peter
denied it; and at once a rooster crowed.
28 From Caiaphas, then, they bring Jesus to the governor's
headquarters.[h] It was early morning.[i] They did not go into the head-
quarters themselves, lest they incur defilement; they wanted to eat
the Passover.[j] 29 Pilate[k] therefore came out to them and says, "What
accusation are you bringing against this man?" 30 They answered him,
"If this man were not a wrongdoer, we would not have handed him
over to you." 31 "You take him," Pilate said to them, "and try him under
your own law." The Jews told him, "We have no legal right to execute
anyone."[l] 32 This was to fulfill the word Jesus had spoken to indicate
by what kind of death he was going to die.

33 Pilate went back inside the headquarters, called for Jesus, and
asked him, “Are you the king of the Jews?” 34 Jesus replied, “Is this
your own question, or did other people say this to you about me?” 35
Pilate replied, “Am I a Jew? Your own people and their chief priests
handed you over to me. What did you do?” 36 “My kingdom is not of
this world,” Jesus answered. “If it were, those who serve me would
be fighting to prevent my being handed over to the Jews. But in fact
my kingdom does not come from here.” 37 “So you are a king?” Pilate
asked. Jesus answered, “You say that I am a king.[m] I was born for this,
and for this I came into the world: to testify to the truth. Everyone
who belongs to the truth hears my voice.” 38 Pilate says to him, “What
is truth?” After saying this, he went out again to the Jews and says
to them, “I find no case against him. 39 It is a custom of yours that I
set someone free for you at the Passover. Would you like me, then, to
set free for you the King of the Jews?” 40 They shouted back, “Not this
man, but Barabbas!”[n] Now Barabbas was a bandit.[o]

Notes

- a (18:1) Kidron ravine: Greek *cheimarros*, a “winter torrent,” a valley that runs with water only in the rainy season, here the Kidron valley east of Jerusalem, between the city and the Mount of Olives.
- b (18:3) Cohort: Greek *speira*, a Roman unit nominally of 600 soldiers, though here perhaps a detachment.
- c (18:5) I am he: Greek *egō eimi*, “I am”; in context an identification, but see the notes on 6:20 and 8:58; the arresting party’s falling to the ground (18:6) suggests the fuller sense. So in 18:6, 8.
- d (18:9) See 6:39; 17:12.
- e (18:10) Malchus: a Semitic name, “king” or “counselor.”
- f (18:12) Commander: Greek *chiliarchos*, “commander of a thousand,” a Roman military tribune.
- g (18:13) Annas: high priest AD 6–15, still powerful afterward; five of his sons and his son-in-law Caiaphas held the office. *Annas* is a Greek form of Hebrew *Hanan*, “gracious.”
- h (18:28) Governor’s headquarters: Greek *praitōrion*, the Roman governor’s residence (praetorium) in Jerusalem, probably Herod’s palace or the Antonia fortress.
- i (18:28) Early morning: Greek *prōi*, the last watch of the night, about 3–6 a.m.
- j (18:28) Eat the Passover: in John, Jesus is crucified on the day of preparation for the Passover (19:14, 31), at the time the lambs were slaughtered; in Matthew, Mark

and Luke the Last Supper is a Passover meal. The relation of the two chronologies is much discussed.

- k (18:29) Pilate: Pontius Pilate, Roman prefect of Judea AD 26–36.
- l (18:31) We have no legal right to execute anyone: under Roman rule the Jewish authorities apparently lacked the right of capital punishment, at least for a case such as this. John 18:31–33 and 37–38 are preserved in P52 (John Rylands Library, Manchester), a small papyrus fragment usually dated about AD 125–175 and one of the oldest surviving New Testament manuscripts.
- m (18:37) You say that I am a king: or "You say it: I am a king." Compare Matt 27:11; Mark 15:2; Luke 23:3.
- n (18:40) Barabbas: Aramaic, "son of the father" (or "son of Abba"). See Matt 27:16–17, where some manuscripts give his name as Jesus Barabbas.
- o (18:40) Bandit: Greek *lēstēs*, a robber, often used by Josephus of armed insurgents against Rome.

Chapter 19

1 Pilate then took Jesus and had him flogged.[a] 2 The soldiers twisted
thorns into a crown and set it upon his head, and threw a purple
robe around him; 3 Again and again they came up to him with "Hail,
King of the Jews!" and struck him in the face. 4 Pilate came outside
once more and says to them, "Here, I am bringing him out to you, so
you may know that I find no case against him." 5 So out came Jesus,
wearing the thorny crown and the purple robe. And Pilate says to
them, "Look: the man!"[b] 6 At the sight of him the chief priests and the
officers shouted, "Crucify, crucify!" Pilate tells them, "You take him
and crucify him; I find no case against him." 7 The Jews answered him,
"We have a law, and by that law he ought to die, for he has made
himself out to be God's Son."
8 When Pilate heard this statement, he grew more afraid than ever. 9
Then he went inside the headquarters again and said to Jesus, "Where
have you come from?" But Jesus did not answer him. 10 So Pilate says
to him, "Will you not speak to me? Do you not realize I have power
to release you, and power to crucify you?" 11 "You would hold no
authority over me at all," Jesus answered, "unless it had been given
you from above.[c] That is why the man who delivered me to you is
guilty of a greater sin." 12 After this Pilate tried to set him free, but the
Jews cried out, "Set this man free, and you are no Friend of Caesar![d]

Whoever makes himself a king is defying Caesar." 13 On hearing these
words, Pilate brought Jesus outside and sat down[e] on the judgment
seat at a place called the Stone Pavement, in Hebrew[f] Gabbatha.[g] 14 It
was the day of Preparation for the Passover, about noon.[h] And he says
to the Jews, "Here is your king!" 15 They shouted, "Away with him!
Away with him! Crucify him!" Pilate says to them, "Shall I crucify
your king?" The chief priests answered, "We have no king but Caesar."
16 So then he delivered him up to them for crucifixion, and they took
Jesus away.
17 He went out, bearing the cross on his own, to the spot known
as Skull Place, Golgotha[i] in Hebrew. 18 They nailed him to the cross
there, and two other men along with him, one on each side and Jesus
between them. 19 Pilate also had a notice[j] written and fixed on the
cross; it read, "JESUS THE NAZARENE, THE KING OF THE JEWS." 20
Many of the Jews read this notice, because the place where Jesus was
crucified was near the city; and it was written in Hebrew, in Latin,
and in Greek. 21 The chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate, "Do not
write, 'The King of the Jews.' Write instead that he claimed, 'I am the
King of the Jews.'" 22 Pilate answered, "What I have written, I have
written."
23 The soldiers, after crucifying Jesus, took his garments and divided
them in four, one portion for each soldier. They took the tunic too;
it had no seam, being woven in one piece throughout from the top. 24
They said to each other, "Let us not tear it. Instead, let us cast lots to
see who will get it." This was so that the Scripture would be fulfilled
that says: "They shared out my clothes among them, and for my robe
they cast lots."[k] And that is what the soldiers did.
25 By the cross of Jesus there stood his mother, and his mother's sister,
Mary the wife of Clopas,[l] and Mary Magdalene.[m] 26 Jesus, seeing his
mother and the disciple whom he loved standing near, says to his
mother, "Woman,[n] here is your son." 27 Next he says to the disciple,
"Here is your mother." From that hour on, the disciple received her
into his own household.
28 After this, Jesus, knowing that all was now accomplished, says (so
that the Scripture might be fulfilled), "I thirst."[o] 29 A jar of sour wine[p]

was sitting there. They soaked a sponge in the wine, fixed it on a branch of hyssop[q], and lifted it to his mouth. 30 Having taken the sour wine, Jesus said, "It is finished";[r] and he bowed his head and handed over his spirit.

31 Now it was the day of Preparation, and the Jews did not want the bodies left on the crosses over the Sabbath, especially as that Sabbath was a high day.[s] So they requested Pilate to have the men's legs broken[t] and the bodies removed. 32 So the soldiers came and broke the legs of the first man, and then of the other who had been crucified with him. 33 But when they got to Jesus and saw that he had already died, they did not break his legs. 34 Instead, one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and blood and water immediately flowed out. 35 The man who saw this has testified to it, and his testimony is true. He knows that he is telling the truth, so that you also may believe. 36 For these things took place to fulfill the Scripture, "Not one bone of his shall be broken."[u] 37 And again another Scripture says, "They will look on him whom they pierced."[v]

38 After this, Joseph of Arimathea,[w] who was a disciple of Jesus, though a secret one for fear of the Jews, asked Pilate whether he might remove the body of Jesus; and Pilate gave permission. So he came and removed his body. 39 Nicodemus came too, the man who had first come to Jesus by night, bringing a mixture[x] of myrrh and aloes, about seventy-five pounds.[y] 40 They took the body of Jesus and wrapped it in linen strips together with the spices, as is the Jewish custom of burial. 41 At the place where he was crucified there was a garden, and in the garden a new tomb in which no one had ever yet been laid. 42 So, because of the Jewish day of Preparation, and because the tomb was close at hand, they laid Jesus there.

Notes

- a (19:1) Flogged: Greek *mastigoō*, the Roman scourging with a whip of leather thongs weighted with bone or metal, often inflicted before crucifixion.
- b (19:5) Look: the man!: or "Here is the man!" (Latin *Ecce homo*).
- c (19:11) From above: that is, from God; the same Greek word as "again"/"from above" in 3:3, 7.

- d (19:12) Friend of Caesar: perhaps an honorary title (Latin *amicus Caesaris*) for officials loyal to the emperor, here Tiberius (AD 14–37). *Caesar* became the imperial title.
- e (19:13) Sat down: or "seated him" (that is, seated Jesus) on the judgment seat; the Greek can be read either way.
- f (19:13) Hebrew: here and in 19:17, 20 probably meaning Aramaic, the everyday language of Jews in the land.
- g (19:13) Gabbatha: an Aramaic name of uncertain meaning, perhaps "height" or "ridge."
- h (19:14) About noon: literally "about the sixth hour," counting from about 6 a.m.; see the note on 1:39. If John reckoned from midnight, as has sometimes been proposed, the time would be about 6 a.m. Mark 15:25 places the crucifixion at the third hour (about 9 a.m.); the two accounts have been reconciled in various ways, and a few manuscripts read "third" here.
- i (19:17) Golgotha: Aramaic *gulgulta*, "skull"; Latin *calvaria*, whence "Calvary."
- j (19:19) Notice: Greek *titlos* (Latin *titulus*), a placard stating the charge against the condemned.
- k (19:24) Ps 22:18 (21:19 Greek), following the Greek Old Testament.
- l (19:25) Mary the wife of Clopas: literally "Mary of Clopas," perhaps "wife" or "daughter." It is uncertain whether three or four women are named (his mother's sister may be a separate person). *Clopas* may be the same as Cleopas (Luke 24:18).
- m (19:25) Mary Magdalene: "Mary of Magdala," a town on the west shore of the Sea of Galilee; *Magdala* means "tower."
- n (19:26) Woman: a respectful form of address (see the note on 2:4).
- o (19:28) I thirst: compare Ps 22:15; 69:21.
- p (19:29) Sour wine: Greek *oxos*, cheap wine vinegar, a common drink of soldiers and laborers.
- q (19:29) Hyssop: a small bushy plant used to sprinkle the blood of the Passover lamb (Exod 12:22). Because its stalk is short, some have conjectured *hyssō*, "on a javelin," a reading found in one late manuscript.
- r (19:30) It is finished: Greek *tetelestai*, "it has been completed, accomplished"; the same verb as "accomplished" in 19:28.
- s (19:31) High day: that Sabbath coincided with the Passover festival (see 19:14 and 18:28).
- t (19:31) Have the men's legs broken: breaking a crucified man's legs (Latin *crurifragium*) hastened death by suffocation.
- u (19:36) Exod 12:46; Num 9:12 (of the Passover lamb); compare Ps 34:20.
- v (19:37) Zech 12:10, in a form closer to the Hebrew than to the Greek Old Testament.
- w (19:38) Arimathea: a town in Judea, perhaps Ramathaim (1 Sam 1:1), about 20 miles (32 km) northwest of Jerusalem. *Joseph* means "may he add."

- x (19:39) Mixture: so the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus (as reported, *heligma*, “package, roll”); most manuscripts read *migma*, “mixture.”
- y (19:39) About seventy-five pounds: literally “about a hundred litras.” The Roman pound (*litra*, Latin *libra*) was about 12 ounces (327 g), so the total was about 75 pounds (33 kg), a quantity fit for a royal burial.

Chapter 20

1 On the first day of the week,[a] early, while it was still dark, Mary
Magdalene comes to the tomb and sees that the stone has been taken
away from the tomb. 2 She runs, then, and comes to Simon Peter and
the other disciple, whom Jesus held dear, and says to them, “They
have removed the Lord from the tomb, and where they have laid him
we cannot tell!” 3 Peter therefore set out with the other disciple, and
they made for the tomb. 4 The two were running side by side, but
the other disciple outran Peter and was first to arrive at the tomb. 5
Stooping to look in, he sees the linen strips lying there; he did not,
however, go in. 6 Then Simon Peter arrives, following him, and he
went into the tomb. He looks at the linen strips lying there, 7 and
the face cloth that had been on his head, not lying with the strips
but rolled up in a place by itself. 8 Then the other disciple, who had
reached the tomb first, went in as well, and he saw and believed; 9
They did not yet grasp the Scripture that he had to rise again out of
death. 10 The disciples then went back home again.
11 But Mary stayed outside by the tomb, weeping. As she wept, she
bent down to look into the tomb, 12 and she sees two angels in white
sitting where the body of Jesus had lain, one at the head and one at
the feet. 13 “Woman,” they say to her, “what are you weeping for?” She
tells them, “Someone has removed my Lord, and where they have laid
him I cannot tell.” 14 On saying this she turned around, and she sees
Jesus standing there, but she did not know that it was Jesus. 15 Jesus
says to her, “Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you looking
for?” She, supposing him to be the gardener, says to him, “Sir, if it
was you who carried him off, tell me where you put him, and I will
take him away.” 16 Jesus says to her, “Mary.” She turns and says to him
in Hebrew, “Rabbouni!”[b] (which means Teacher). 17 Jesus told her, “Do

not cling to me,[c] since I have not yet ascended to the Father. Rather,
go to my brothers and give them this message: 'I am going up to my
Father, who is also your Father, to my God, who is also your God.'"
18 Mary Magdalene goes and announces to the disciples, "I have seen
the Lord," and that he had told her these things.
19 When evening came on that day, the first day of the week, and the
doors of the place where the disciples were had been locked for fear of
the Jews, Jesus came and stood among them and says to them, "Peace
be with you." 20 And after saying this he showed them his hands and
his side. The disciples were overjoyed at seeing the Lord. 21 So Jesus
said to them again, "Peace be with you. As the Father has sent me, so
I am sending you." 22 Having said this, he breathed on them[d] and says
to them, "Receive the Holy Spirit. 23 If you forgive anyone's sins, they
stand forgiven; if you retain anyone's, they stand retained."
24 Thomas, however, one of the Twelve, the one called the Twin,[e] had
been absent when Jesus came. 25 So the other disciples told him, "We
have seen the Lord." But he said to them, "I will never believe unless
I see the nail marks in his hands, touch those marks with my finger,
and put my hand into his side."
26 Eight days later[f] his disciples were again indoors, and Thomas was
with them. Though the doors were locked, Jesus comes and stood
among them and said, "Peace be with you." 27 Then he said to Thomas,
"Put your finger here and look at my hands. Reach out your hand and
place it in my side. Do not be unbelieving,[g] but believe." 28 Thomas
answered him, "My Lord and my God!"[h] 29 Jesus says to him, "Because
you have seen me, you have believed? Blessed are those who have
not seen and yet have believed."
30 Now Jesus did many other signs in the presence of the disciples,
which are not written in this book; 31 These, though, have been written
that you may believe[i] Jesus to be the Messiah, God's Son, and that
through believing you may have life by his name.

Notes

- a (20:1) The first day of the week: literally "on the first of the sabbaths," that is, of the week; our Sunday.
- b (20:16) Rabbouni: an Aramaic form of "Rabbi," literally "my master," "my teacher."

- c (20:17) Stop clinging to me: or "Do not hold on to me"; the present imperative suggests stopping an action already begun. The older rendering "Touch me not" is from the Latin *Noli me tangere*.
- d (20:22) Breathed on them: Greek *enephysēsen*, the verb used in the Greek Old Testament of God breathing life into the first man (Gen 2:7) and in Ezek 37:9.
- e (20:24) Twin: see the note on 11:16.
- f (20:26) Eight days later: counting inclusively, the following Sunday.
- g (20:27) Stop doubting: literally "Do not be unbelieving, but believing."
- h (20:28) My Lord and my God: compare 1:1, 18. *Lord and God* was a combination used of the God of Israel in the Greek Old Testament (for example Ps 35:23).
- i (20:31) May believe: so the Westcott–Hort text with P66 (apparently), Sinaiticus (first hand) and Vaticanus (as reported), a present tense that may mean "continue to believe"; most manuscripts read the aorist, which may mean "come to believe." Many scholars regard 20:30–31 as the original ending of the Gospel, with chapter 21 an epilogue; no manuscript lacks chapter 21.

Chapter 21

1 Later, Jesus again made himself known to the disciples beside the
Sea of Tiberias.[a] This is how he made himself known. 2 Simon Peter,
Thomas (known as the Twin), Nathanael of Cana in Galilee, the sons
of Zebedee,[b] and two other disciples of Jesus were together. 3 Simon
Peter says to them, "I am going fishing." They say to him, "We will
come with you." They went out and got into the boat, and that night
they caught nothing. 4 At daybreak Jesus was standing on the beach,
but the disciples did not realize that it was Jesus. 5 So Jesus says to
them, "Lads,[c] you have no fish to eat, have you?" They answered him,
"No." 6 He said to them, "Cast the net on the right-hand side of the
boat, and you will find some." So they cast it, and now they could not
haul it in for the great number of fish. 7 The disciple whom Jesus loved
said to Peter, "It is the Lord!" When Simon Peter heard that it was
the Lord, he wrapped his outer garment around himself (he had been
working without it) and jumped into the sea. 8 The other disciples
followed in the small boat, pulling the net full of fish, since they were
not far from shore, only about a hundred yards.[d] 9 When they got out
onto the land, they see a charcoal fire laid there, with fish lying on it,
and bread. 10 Jesus says to them, "Bring some of the fish you have just
caught." 11 Simon Peter therefore climbed up and dragged the net to
land, crammed with big fish, one hundred fifty-three[e] in all; and for

all their number, the net did not split. 12 “Come and eat,” says Jesus to
them. Not one of the disciples ventured to inquire, “Who are you?”
for they knew it was the Lord. 13 Jesus comes and takes the bread and
gives it to them, and the fish likewise. 14 That made the third time
Jesus appeared to the disciples after rising from the dead.
15 When they had eaten breakfast, Jesus says to Simon Peter, “Simon
son of John,[f] do you love me more than these?”[g] He says to him, “Yes,
Lord; you know that I love you.”[h] He says to him, “Feed my lambs.” 16
He says to him again, a second time, “Simon son of John, do you love
me?” He says to him, “Yes, Lord; you know that I love you.” He says to
him, “Shepherd my sheep.” 17 A third time he says to him, “Simon son
of John, do you love me?” It hurt Peter that he asked him a third time,
“Do you love me?” and he answered, “Lord, you know everything;
you are aware that I love you.” Jesus says to him, “Feed my sheep.
18 Amen, amen, I tell you, in your youth you put on your own belt
and went about where you pleased; but when you have grown old,
you will stretch out your hands,[i] and someone else will belt you and
lead you where you would not go.” 19 He said this to show the kind
of death by which Peter would bring glory to God. Then he told him,
“Follow me.”
20 Peter turned and sees the disciple whom Jesus loved following them,
the one who had leaned back against his chest at the supper and said,
“Lord, who is it that is betraying you?” 21 Seeing him, Peter says to
Jesus, “Lord, and what about him?” 22 Jesus says to him, “Suppose I
wish him to stay until I come; what concern is that of yours? As for
you, follow me.” 23 Hence the report went out among the brothers that
this disciple was not going to die. But Jesus had not said to him that
he would not die; only, “Suppose I wish him to stay until I come; what
concern is that of yours?”
24 This is the disciple who bears witness about these things and who
has written them, and we know that his witness is true.[j]
25 Jesus did many other things besides. Were they to be written down
one by one, I imagine the world itself would not have room for the
books that would be written.[k]

Notes

- a (21:1) Sea of Tiberias: the Sea of Galilee (see the note on 6:1).
- b (21:2) The sons of Zebedee: James and John, mentioned only here in this Gospel. *Zebedee* is from Hebrew, “gift (of Yahweh).”
- c (21:5) Lads: Greek *paidia*, “children,” a familiar form of address.
- d (21:8) About a hundred yards: literally “about two hundred cubits,” about 300 feet (90 m).
- e (21:11) One hundred fifty-three: many symbolic interpretations have been proposed (for example, Jerome reported that Greek zoologists counted 153 kinds of fish), but none is certain.
- f (21:15) Simon son of John: so the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts read “Simon son of Jonah,” as in Matt 16:17. So in 21:16, 17. See the note on 1:42.
- g (21:15) More than these: either “more than these others do” or “more than you love these things.”
- h (21:15) Love … love: in 21:15–17 Jesus twice asks with *agapaō* and the third time with *phileō*, while Peter answers each time with *phileō*. Many interpreters see the change as stylistic variation, since John uses both verbs of the same love (compare 3:35 and 5:20); others find a deliberate distinction.
- i (21:18) Stretch out your hands: early Christian writers took this as a reference to crucifixion; tradition holds that Peter was crucified in Rome under Nero, about AD 64–67.
- j (21:24) We know that his witness is true: the “we” appears to be a group associated with the beloved disciple who vouch for his testimony; see the note on 13:23.
- k (21:25) The books that would be written: in the manuscripts of family 1 (as reported), the account of the woman caught in adultery (7:53–8:11) is placed after this verse; see the note on 7:53.

Acts

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 In my former book, Theophilus,[a] I gave an account of all that Jesus
began to do and to teach, 2 until the day on which he was taken up,
having by the Holy Spirit laid his commands upon the apostles whom
he had chosen. 3 To them also, after his suffering, he presented himself
alive by many convincing proofs, appearing to them over a period of
forty days and speaking about the kingdom of God. 4 And while he
was at table with them,[b] he directed them that they were not to depart
from Jerusalem, but to remain there awaiting the Father's promise,
"of which," he said, "you have heard me speak; 5 for John baptized
with water, but you will be baptized in the Holy Spirit not many days
from now."
6 So those who had gathered asked him again and again, "Lord, is it
now, at this time, that you will give back the kingdom to Israel?" 7
He told them, "It is not for you to know times or seasons that the
Father has fixed by his own authority. 8 But power will be yours when
the Holy Spirit comes upon you, and in Jerusalem, in all Judea and
Samaria, and as far as the end of the earth, you shall be witnesses
for me." 9 And having said these things, he was raised up while they
watched, and a cloud received him and hid him from their eyes. 10
While they were gazing intently toward heaven as he went, all at
once two men in white garments stood beside them, 11 who said, "Men
of Galilee, why do you stand looking up into the sky? This Jesus, who
has been taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way
as you saw him going into heaven."
12 Then they went back to Jerusalem from the hill called the Mount
of Olives, which is near Jerusalem, about half a mile away.[c] 13 On
entering the city they went up to the upstairs room where they
were lodging: Peter and John and James and Andrew, Philip and

Thomas, Bartholomew and Matthew, James son of Alphaeus, Simon the Zealot,[d] and Judas son of James. 14 All of these were united in constant prayer, along with the women, including Mary, the mother of Jesus, and his brothers.

15 In those days Peter stood up among the brothers and sisters[e] (a crowd of about a hundred and twenty persons was gathered together) and said,

16 "Brothers, the Scripture had to come true, the words the Holy Spirit spoke long ago through David about Judas, who served as the guide for the men who arrested Jesus.

17 For he was counted as one of us and was allotted his share in this ministry."

18 (This man, then, got himself a piece of land out of the reward of his crime; and falling headlong,[f] he split open in his midsection, and his inward parts all poured out.

19 And it came to be known by everyone living in Jerusalem, so that the plot was called in their language Akeldama, that is, Field of Blood.)[g]

20 "For it is written in the Book of Psalms,

'May his place be left empty,
and may no one live in it,'[h]
and,
'May someone else take over his position.'[i]

21 So of the men who have accompanied us during all the time that the Lord Jesus went in and out among us,

22 beginning from the baptism of John until the day when he was taken up from us — one of these must become with us a witness to his resurrection."

23 They put forward two: Joseph called Barsabbas,[j] who was surnamed Justus, and Matthias.[k]

24 They prayed, "Lord, you know every person's heart. Show us which of these two men you have chosen

25 to take the place in this ministry and apostleship from which Judas turned aside to go to his own place."

26 And they gave lots for them, and the lot fell upon Matthias; and he was reckoned along with the eleven apostles.

Notes

- a (1:1) Theophilus: “friend of God” or “dear to God”; compare Luke 1:3.
- b (1:4) At table with them: Greek *synalizomenos*, of uncertain meaning, perhaps “eating salt with them,” or “gathering them together,” or (if from a different verb) “staying with them.”
- c (1:12) About half a mile away: literally “a sabbath day’s journey away,” the distance a person was permitted to walk on the sabbath, about 2,000 cubits, roughly 3/5 mile (1 kilometer).
- d (1:13) Zealot: Greek *zēlōtēs*, “zealous one,” perhaps a member of the party opposed to Roman rule, or simply one zealous for the Law.
- e (1:15) Brothers and sisters: Greek *adelphoi*, used of the whole community of believers; in 1:16 Peter addresses the men (*andres adelphoi*).
- f (1:18) Falling headlong: Greek *prēnēs genomenos*; some interpret it as “swelling up.” Compare Matt 27:3–10.
- g (1:19) Akeldama: Aramaic *ḥaqel dema*, “field of blood.”
- h (1:20) Ps 69:25 (Greek Ps 68:26).
- i (1:20) Ps 109:8 (Greek Ps 108:8).
- j (1:23) Barsabbas: Aramaic, probably “son of the sabbath.”
- k (1:23) Matthias: a shortened form of Mattathias, “gift of Yahweh.”

Chapter 2

1 When the day of Pentecost[a] arrived, they were all gathered in one
place. 2 And suddenly out of heaven there came a sound like a violent
wind rushing along, and it filled the whole house where they sat. 3
And tongues as if of fire appeared to them, being distributed, and one
settled upon each of them. 4 They were all filled with the Holy Spirit
and began to speak in other tongues,[b] as the Spirit was giving them
to utter.
5 Now there were Jews dwelling in Jerusalem, devout men from every
nation under heaven. 6 And when this sound arose, the multitude
gathered, and confusion seized them, since every one of them heard
the speakers in his own dialect. 7 Amazed and astonished, they said,
“Look, are not all these who are speaking Galileans? 8 How then is
it that each of us hears them in the very language we were born to?
9 Parthians and Medes and Elamites, and residents of Mesopotamia,
Judea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia,[c] 10 Phrygia and Pamphylia,
Egypt and the regions of Libya around Cyrene, and Roman visitors
(Jews and also proselytes[d]), 11 Cretans and Arabs. We hear them

declaring the wonderful acts of God in our own languages!" 12 All were
amazed and perplexed, saying one to another, "What can this mean?"
13 But others mocked and said, "They have had too much new wine."
14 Then Peter took his stand with the Eleven and addressed the crowd
in a loud voice: "People of Judea and everyone living in Jerusalem, I
want you to understand this. Pay attention to my words.
15 For these men are not drunk, as you suppose, since it is only nine
o'clock in the morning.[e]
16 Rather, here is the thing foretold by Joel the prophet:
17 'And it shall be in the last days, says God,
that I will pour out some of my Spirit on all flesh;
and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy,
and your young men shall see visions,
and your old men shall dream dreams;
18 yes, even on my male slaves and on my female slaves
in those days I will pour out some of my Spirit,
and they shall prophesy.
19 And I will give wonders in the heaven above
and signs on the earth beneath,
blood and fire and a vapor of smoke;
20 the sun shall be changed into darkness
and the moon into blood,
before the coming of the great and glorious day of the Lord.
21 And then everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.'[f]
22 "People of Israel, listen to this: Jesus of Nazareth was a man whom
God confirmed to you by miracles, wonders and signs, which God
performed through him among you, as you yourselves know.
23 this man, given up by the set purpose and foreknowledge of God,
you nailed up by the hands of lawless men and killed.
24 God raised him up, having loosed the pangs of death,[g] because it
was not possible for him to be held in its grip.
25 For David says concerning him,
'I saw the Lord always before me,
for he is at my right hand so that I may not be shaken;

26 therefore my heart was glad and my tongue rejoiced;
moreover my flesh also will dwell in hope.
27 For you will not leave my soul behind in Hades,[h]
nor give over your Holy One to see decay.
28 The ways of life you have shown to me;
with joy before your face you will fill me full.'[i]
29 "Brothers, it is permitted to speak freely to you about the patriarch David: he died and was buried, and his grave is among us even to this day.
30 So, since he was a prophet and knew God had sworn an oath to him that from the fruit of his body[j] one would be set upon his throne,
31 he looked ahead and spoke of the Messiah's resurrection, that neither was he left behind in Hades, nor did his flesh see decay.
32 This Jesus God raised up, and of that we are all witnesses.
33 Exalted therefore to[k] the right hand of God, and having received from the Father the promised Holy Spirit, he has poured out this which you both see and hear.
34 For it was not David who went up into heaven; yet he says,
'The Lord said to my Lord,
"Take your seat at my right,
35 until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet."'[l]
36 So let the whole nation of Israel know with certainty that God has made this Jesus, whom you crucified, both Lord and Messiah."
37 When they heard this they were stabbed to the heart, and said to Peter and the rest of the apostles, "Brothers, what are we to do?"
38 Peter said to them, "Repent, and be baptized, each one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins; and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. 39 For to you is the promise, and to your children, and to all who are far off, as many as the Lord our God shall call to himself." 40 And with many other words he bore witness and kept urging them, saying, "Be saved from this crooked generation." 41 So those who welcomed his word were baptized, and that day about three thousand souls were added.
42 And they were steadfast in what the apostles taught and in the fellowship,[m] in the breaking of the bread and in the prayers. 43 Awe

came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were being done through the apostles.[n] 44 All who believed were together and held everything in common; 45 they would sell their properties and possessions and distribute the proceeds to all, as anyone had need. 46 Every day they met together in the temple with a common purpose, and they broke bread in their homes. They ate together with joyful and generous hearts, 47 They praised God and were respected by all the people. And daily the Lord increased[o] the number of those who were being saved.

Notes

- a (2:1) Pentecost: Greek *pentēkostē*, "fiftieth," the Feast of Weeks, held fifty days after Passover (Lev 23:15–21).
- b (2:4) Tongues: or "languages"; the same Greek word (*glōssa*) is used in 2:3, 4, 11.
- c (2:9) Asia: the Roman province in western Asia Minor, not the continent.
- d (2:10) Proselytes: Gentile converts to Judaism.
- e (2:15) Nine o'clock in the morning: literally "the third hour of the day."
- f (2:21) Joel 2:28–32 (Greek and Hebrew 3:1–5), with "in the last days" (for "afterward") and "says God" added. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" in 2:20 and 2:21 is Yahweh.
- g (2:24) Pangs of death: literally "the birth pains of death"; the phrase may reflect a Hebrew idiom meaning "the cords of death" (Ps 18:4–5).
- h (2:27) Hades: Greek *hadēs*, the realm of the dead, rendering Hebrew *Sheol*.
- i (2:28) Ps 16:8–11 (Greek Ps 15:8–11). In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" in 2:25 is Yahweh.
- j (2:30) From the fruit of his body: literally "from the fruit of his loins," that is, one of his descendants; compare Ps 132:11. Many later manuscripts add "according to the flesh, to raise up the Messiah."
- k (2:33) To: or "by."
- l (2:35) Ps 110:1 (Greek Ps 109:1). In the Hebrew, "The Lord said" is "Yahweh said"; "my Lord" is *adoni*, "my master."
- m (2:42) Fellowship: Greek *koinōnia*, "sharing, partnership, communion."
- n (2:43) Through the apostles: many manuscripts add "in Jerusalem, and great fear was upon all."
- o (2:47) To their number: literally "together" (*epi to auto*). Many later manuscripts add "to the church."

Chapter 3

1 Now Peter and John were going up to the temple at the hour of prayer, at three in the afternoon.[a] 2 And a certain man, lame since

birth, was being carried there; every day people would lay him at that
temple gate which is called Beautiful, so he could ask alms from those
entering the temple. 3 When he saw Peter and John about to enter the
temple, he asked them for money. 4 Peter, fixing his eyes upon him
together with John, said, "Look at us." 5 So he held his gaze on them,
looking to receive some gift from them. 6 But Peter said, "Silver and
gold are not mine to give, but what is mine I give to you: in the name
of Jesus Christ the Nazarene, walk!" 7 And seizing him by the right
hand he raised him up; and immediately the soles of his feet and his
ankles grew firm. 8 He jumped to his feet and began to walk. Then he
went into the temple with them, walking, jumping, and praising God.
9 All the people saw him walking and praising God, 10 They realized
he was the man who used to sit and beg at the temple's Beautiful
Gate, and they were filled with amazement and wonder at what had
happened to him.
11 While he clung to Peter and John, all the people ran together to
them in the colonnade[b] called Solomon's, utterly astonished. 12 Seeing
this, Peter addressed the people: "Men of Israel, why do you marvel
at this, or why stare at us, as though by our own power or godliness
we had made him walk? 13 The God of Abraham and of Isaac and of
Jacob, the God of our fathers, has glorified his servant[c] Jesus, whom
you handed over and disowned in the presence of Pilate, when he had
decided to release him. 14 But you disowned the Holy and Righteous
One and asked for a murderer to be granted to you, 15 and the Author[d]
of life you put to death — whom God has raised out from among the
dead, of which we are witnesses. 16 And by faith in his name, his name
has made strong this man whom you see and know; and the faith that
comes through Jesus has given him this perfect health in the presence
of you all.
17 "And now, brothers, I am aware that it was out of ignorance that you
did it, just as your rulers did. 18 But what God foretold by the mouth of
all the prophets, that his Messiah would suffer, he has thus fulfilled. 19
So change your hearts and turn back to God, so that your sins may be
erased and seasons of renewal may come from the Lord's presence,[e]
20 and so that he may send Jesus, the Messiah chosen for you, 21 whom

heaven must receive until the times of the restoration of all things,
of which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets from of old.
22 For Moses said, ‘A prophet like me the Lord your God will raise up
for you out of your brothers; you are to hear him in everything he
may speak to you. 23 Everyone who will not obey that prophet will be
wiped out and separated from the people.’[f] 24 And all the prophets too,
from Samuel and those who came after him, as many as have spoken,
also announced these days. 25 You are the descendants of the prophets
and heirs of the covenant that God made with your ancestors. He
told Abraham, ‘Through your offspring[g] every family on earth will
be blessed.’[h] 26 God, having raised up his servant, sent him to you first,
to bless you by turning every one of you from your wicked ways.”

Notes

- a (3:1) At three in the afternoon: literally “the ninth hour,” the time of the afternoon sacrifice and prayer.
- b (3:11) Colonnade: Greek *stoa*, a roofed portico along the eastern side of the temple court.
- c (3:13) Servant: Greek *pais*, “servant” or “child”; compare Isa 52:13 (Greek), “my servant shall be glorified.”
- d (3:15) Author: Greek *archēgos*, “founder, originator, leader, pioneer.”
- e (3:19) From the presence of the Lord: some editions begin verse 20 with “that times of refreshing may come,” following a different verse division.
- f (3:23) Deut 18:15–19, with Lev 23:29. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” in 3:22 is Yahweh.
- g (3:25) Offspring: literally “seed.”
- h (3:25) Gen 22:18; 26:4.

Chapter 4

1 As they were speaking to the people, the priests[a] and the captain of
the temple and the Sadducees came upon them, 2 annoyed because
they were instructing the people and proclaiming, in the case of Jesus,
the resurrection from among the dead. 3 They laid hands on them and
put them in custody until the next day, since evening had already
come. 4 But many who heard the word came to believe, and the men
among them numbered about five thousand.
5 On the following day it happened that their rulers and elders and
scribes were gathered together in Jerusalem,

6 with Annas the high priest, and Caiaphas, John,[b] Alexander, and all
who belonged to the high-priestly family.
7 Having made the two stand in their midst, they began to inquire:
"By what sort of power, or in what sort of name, have such men as
you done this?"
8 Then Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, said to them, "Rulers of the
people and elders,
9 since today we are on trial concerning a good deed to a man who
was ill — by what means he has been restored —
10 be it known to all of you and to all the people of Israel that it is in
the name of Jesus Christ the Nazarene, whom you crucified, whom
God raised from the dead — by him[c] this man stands here before you
in good health.
11 He is
'the stone that was treated with contempt by you, the builders,
which has become the head of the corner.'[d]
12 And salvation is in no one else; for under heaven there is no other
name given among human beings by which we must be saved."
13 When they observed how boldly Peter and John spoke, and grasped
that they were uneducated men without special training,[e] they were
amazed; and they took note that these had been with Jesus. 14 And
seeing the man who had been healed standing there with them, they
had nothing to say against it. 15 So, ordering them to go out of the
council,[f] they conferred among themselves, 16 saying, "What are we
to do about these men? For it is evident to all the inhabitants of
Jerusalem that a remarkable sign has come about by their means, and
denying it is beyond us. 17 Still, to keep this from spreading further
among the people, let us threaten them so they no longer speak in
this name to any person at all." 18 So they called them and commanded
them not to utter a sound or teach at all in the name of Jesus. 19 But
Peter and John answered them, "Whether it is right in the sight of
God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge; 20 for as for
us, we cannot help speaking of what we have seen and heard." 21 After
threatening them further they let them go, finding no way to punish
them because of the people, for all were glorifying God for what had

taken place. 22 For he was a man of over forty years, the one on whom
this healing sign had come about.
23 Once set free, they came to their companions and told them every-
thing the chief priests and elders had said.
24 Hearing it, they lifted their voices to God with one mind and said,
"Sovereign Lord, you who made the heaven and the earth and the sea
and everything in them,
25 who through the Holy Spirit, by the mouth of our father David your
servant, said:[g]
'Why did the nations rage,
and the peoples plot vain things?
26 The kings of the earth took their stand,
and the rulers were gathered together,
against the Lord and against his Anointed.'[h]
27 In fact, in this very city Herod and Pontius Pilate joined together
with the Gentiles and the peoples of Israel against your holy servant
Jesus, whom you anointed,
28 to do whatever your hand and your purpose had decided beforehand
should happen.
29 And now, Lord, look upon their threats, and grant your slaves to
speak your word with all boldness,
30 as you reach out your hand for healing, and as signs and wonders
come about by the name of your holy servant Jesus."
31 After they prayed, the building where they were meeting shook. All
of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and kept on speaking God's
message fearlessly.
32 Now the whole company of those who had believed were of one
heart and soul, and not one of them said that any of his possessions
was his own, but they had everything in common. 33 With great
power the apostles kept giving their testimony to the resurrection of
the Lord Jesus, and great grace was upon them all. 34 For there was
not a needy person among them, since as many as were owners of
lands or houses would sell them and bring the proceeds of what was
sold 35 and they would put it down at the feet of the apostles; and
distribution was made to each according to his need. 36 Thus Joseph,

who was called by the apostles Barnabas[i] (which translated means "son of encouragement"), a Levite, a native of Cyprus, 37 he had a field, and selling it he brought the proceeds and set them down at the feet of the apostles.

Notes

- a (4:1) Priests: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and most manuscripts; Vaticanus and Alexandrinus read "chief priests."
- b (4:6) John: Codex Bezae and some other witnesses read "Jonathan," the name of a son of Annas who was high priest in AD 36–37.
- c (4:10) By him: or "in this name."
- d (4:11) Ps 118:22 (Greek Ps 117:22).
- e (4:13) Without special training: Greek *idiōtai*, "laymen, ordinary people," here those without formal training in the Law.
- f (4:15) Council: Greek *synedrion*, the Sanhedrin, the Jewish high council in Jerusalem.
- g (4:25) The Greek of this verse is unusually difficult and may have suffered early corruption; it reads literally, "who of our father through the Holy Spirit mouth of David your servant saying." Many later manuscripts read more simply, "who by the mouth of your servant David said."
- h (4:26) Ps 2:1–2. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh; "his Anointed" is "his messiah."
- i (4:36) Barnabas: the explanation given, "son of encouragement" (or "of exhortation"), is not an exact etymology; the name may derive from Aramaic *bar nebuʾah*, "son of prophecy," or from a name meaning "son of Nebo." The meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 5

1 Now a man by the name of Ananias,[a] together with Sapphira[b] his wife, sold some land, 2 and holding back for himself some of the price, with his wife also aware of it, he brought a part only and set it down at the feet of the apostles. 3 Peter said, "Ananias, why has Satan taken over your heart, so that you lied to the Holy Spirit and kept back part of the money you received for the land? 4 As long as it was kept, was it not still yours to keep? And once sold, did not the money lie within your own power? How did you come to plan such a thing in your heart? It is not to people that you have lied, but to God." 5 And on hearing these words Ananias fell and expired; and a great fear seized

everyone who heard. 6 The young men got up, wrapped his body,
carried it out, and buried it.
7 Some three hours passed, and then his wife entered, unaware of
what had taken place. 8 Peter said to her, "Tell me whether you sold
the land for so much." And she said, "Yes, for so much." 9 Peter said to
her, "Why did the two of you agree to try the Spirit of the Lord? Listen
— at the door are the feet of the men who buried your husband, and
they will carry you out too." 10 And at once she dropped at his feet and
expired. The young men came in, found her lying dead, and carried
her out and buried her next to her husband. 11 Great fear gripped the
entire church[c] and everyone else who heard about these events.
12 Many signs and wonders were being done among the people by
the apostles. All the believers used to meet together in agreement in
Solomon's Colonnade. 13 None of the rest dared to join them, though
the people held them in high esteem. 14 Yet more and more those who
believed in the Lord were added, multitudes of both men and women,
15 The result was that people would bring the sick out even into the
broad streets and put them on cots and pallets, so that as Peter passed,
his shadow at any rate might overshadow one of them.[d] 16 And a
multitude also came together from the cities surrounding Jerusalem,
carrying those who were ill and those tormented by unclean spirits,
and every one of them was cured.
17 Then the high priest stood up, with all his associates — the sect of
the Sadducees, as it then was — and they were filled with jealousy,
18 they laid hands on the apostles and put them in the public prison.
19 But during the night an angel of the Lord opened the doors of the
prison, brought them out, and said, 20 "Go, take your stand in the
temple, and tell the people every word of this Life." 21 When they heard
this, they went into the temple near dawn and taught. Meanwhile
the high priest arrived with his associates, and they convened the
council and the whole body of the elders of the sons of Israel, and
sent to the prison to have the apostles brought in. 22 When the officers
arrived, they did not find the apostles in the prison. So they went
back and reported, 23 "We found the jail locked up with all security
and the guards standing at the doors, but when we opened them we

found no one inside." 24 When the captain of the temple guard and
the chief priests heard this report, they were baffled and wondered
where it would lead. 25 Then someone arrived and reported to them,
"Look! The men you put in the prison are standing in the temple
and teaching the people." 26 Then the captain went with the officers
and fetched them, though without violence, because they feared the
people might stone them.
27 When they had brought them, they set them before the council.
And the high priest questioned them, 28 He said, "We strictly ordered
you not to teach in this name. Yet you have filled Jerusalem with
your teaching, and you are determined to make us responsible for
this man's death." 29 But Peter and the apostles answered, "We must
obey God rather than human beings. 30 The God of our fathers raised
up Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree.[e] 31 Him God
has lifted up to his right hand as Leader and Savior, to grant Israel
repentance and the forgiveness of sins. 32 And we are witnesses of
these things,[f] and so is the Holy Spirit, whom God has given to those
who obey him."
33 On hearing this they were enraged[g] and were determined to do
away with them. 34 But a member of the council stood up, a Pharisee
named Gamaliel,[h] a teacher of the Law honored by the whole people,
and gave orders that the men be taken outside for a short time. 35
Then he spoke to the council: "Men of Israel, consider well what you
intend to do to these men. 36 For before these days Theudas appeared,
saying that he was someone important, and around four hundred
men attached themselves to him. He was slain, and all his followers
were broken up and reduced to nothing. 37 After this man Judas the
Galilean appeared at the time of the census[i] and led a following away
after him; he likewise perished, and his followers were all scattered
abroad. 38 So now I say to you, stand back from these men and leave
them be; for if this counsel or this work comes from human beings,
it will be brought to ruin; 39 but if it is from God, you will not be able
to overthrow them. You might even be found fighting against God!"
So they were persuaded by him, 40 They called the apostles in and
had them beaten.[j] Then they warned them to say nothing more in the

name of Jesus, and let them go. 41 They went out from the presence
of the council rejoicing that they had been counted worthy to suffer
dishonor for the sake of the Name. 42 Day after day, in the temple and
in people's homes, they never stopped teaching and announcing the
good news that Jesus is the Messiah.

Notes

- a (5:1) Ananias: Hebrew *Ḥananyah*, "Yahweh has been gracious."
- b (5:1) Sapphira: probably Aramaic, "beautiful," or from the word for "sapphire."
- c (5:11) Church: Greek *ekklēsia*, "assembly, congregation"; this is the first use of the word in Acts.
- d (5:15) Some of them: Codex Bezae and some other witnesses add, "for they were set free from every sickness that each of them had."
- e (5:30) Tree: or "cross"; literally "wood." Compare Deut 21:22–23.
- f (5:32) Of these things: literally "of these words." Some manuscripts add "his witnesses" or "in him."
- g (5:33) Furious: literally "sawn through," that is, cut to the quick.
- h (5:34) Gamaliel: Hebrew, "God is my reward"; the grandson (or son) of Hillel and teacher of Paul (22:3).
- i (5:37) Census: the registration under Quirinius in AD 6 (compare Luke 2:2), which provoked Judas's revolt.
- j (5:40) Beat them: that is, had them flogged, probably with the thirty-nine lashes (Deut 25:3; 2 Cor 11:24).

Chapter 6

1 In those days, as the disciples were growing in number, a complaint
arose from the Hellenists[a] against the Hebrews, because their widows
were being passed over in the daily distribution.[b] 2 So the Twelve
called the whole body of the disciples together and said, "It would
not be fitting for us to leave the word of God behind in order to
wait on tables. 3 Instead, brothers, pick out from among you seven
men of good report, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will
put in charge of this need. 4 As for us, we will hold fast to prayer
and to the ministry of the word." 5 What they said pleased the entire
gathering, and they chose Stephen,[c] a man full of faith and of the
Holy Spirit, along with Philip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas,
and Nicolaus, a proselyte from Antioch. 6 These men they set in front
of the apostles, and after praying, the apostles placed their hands on
them. 7 And the word of God kept spreading, and in Jerusalem the

number of the disciples multiplied greatly, and a large company of the priests became obedient to the faith.
8 And Stephen, a man full of grace[d] and power, did great signs and wonders among the people. 9 But some men stood up from the synagogue called that of the Freedmen[e] (made up of Cyrenians and Alexandrians, and of people from Cilicia and Asia) and began to dispute with Stephen; 10 and they had not the strength to stand up against the wisdom and the Spirit with which he was speaking. 11 Then they secretly put forward men who said, "We have heard this man utter blasphemous words against Moses and against God." 12 So they stirred up the people and the elders and the scribes, and coming upon him they seized him and led him to the council. 13 They produced false witnesses, who testified, "This fellow keeps on speaking against this holy place and against the Law. 14 We have heard him claim that Jesus of Nazareth will destroy this place and change the customs Moses passed on to us." 15 And everyone seated in the council stared at him, and they saw his face, as it were an angel's face.

Notes

- a (6:1) Hellenists: Greek-speaking Jews, probably from outside the land of Israel; "the Hebrews" were those whose language was Aramaic (or Hebrew).
- b (6:1) Distribution: literally "service" (*diakonia*), here the daily provision of food.
- c (6:5) Stephen: Greek *Stephanos*, "crown, wreath."
- d (6:8) Grace: many later manuscripts read "faith."
- e (6:9) Freedmen: Greek *Libertinoi*, from Latin *libertini*, Jews who had been slaves (or whose ancestors had been) and were set free. The Greek may describe one synagogue or several.

Chapter 7

1 And the high priest said, "Are these things so?" 2 Stephen replied: "Brothers and fathers, listen. The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham while he was in Mesopotamia, before he settled in Haran,[a] 3 'Leave your land and your family, and go to the land I will show you.'[b] 4 So he left the country of the Chaldeans and lived in Haran; and from there, once his father had died, God moved him to this land where you are living today. 5 Yet he gave him no inheritance in it, not even room to set his foot, though he promised to give it to him as a possession,

and to his descendants after him, at a time when he had no child. 6
This is what God said: that his offspring would live as sojourners in a
foreign country, and its people would make slaves of them and treat
them harshly for four hundred years. 7 'But I will judge the nation
whom they serve,' said God, 'and afterward they will go out and serve
me in this place.'[c] 8 And he gave him the covenant of circumcision.
So Abraham became the father of Isaac, and circumcised him on the
eighth day; and Isaac became the father of Jacob, and Jacob of the
twelve patriarchs.
9 "The patriarchs, envious of Joseph, sold him into Egypt; but God
was with him, 10 and rescued him out of all his afflictions, and gave
him favor and wisdom before Pharaoh king of Egypt, who appointed
him governor over Egypt and over his whole household. 11 Then a
famine came over all of Egypt and Canaan, with great affliction, and
our fathers could find no food. 12 But when Jacob heard there was
grain in Egypt, he sent our fathers out on their first visit. 13 And at
the second time Joseph was recognized by his brothers, and Pharaoh
learned of Joseph's family. 14 Then Joseph sent and summoned Jacob
his father and all his kindred, seventy-five persons[d] in all; 15 and Jacob
went down [into Egypt]. There he died, he and our fathers, 16 And
they were brought over to Shechem and placed in the grave which
Abraham had purchased with silver money from the sons of Hamor
in Shechem.[e]
17 "But as the time drew near for the promise that God had granted
to Abraham, the people grew and multiplied in Egypt, 18 until there
arose over Egypt another king, one who did not know Joseph. 19 He
dealt craftily with our race and mistreated our fathers, forcing them
to abandon their infants so that they would not survive. 20 It was at
this time that Moses was born, and he was a beautiful child in God's
eyes.[f] For three months he was cared for in his father's house. 21 and
when he was put out, Pharaoh's daughter adopted him and raised
him as her own son. 22 And Moses was trained in all the wisdom of the
Egyptians, and was mighty in his words and deeds. 23 "When he was
turning forty years old, it came into his heart to visit his brothers,
the sons of Israel. 24 And seeing one of them being wronged, he came

to his defense and avenged the oppressed man by striking down the Egyptian. 25 He thought his brothers would see that through his hand God was giving them rescue; but they did not see it. 26 The following day he came upon two of them in a fight, and he sought to make peace between them: 'Men, brothers you are! Why are you harming each other?' 27 But the man who was mistreating his fellow Israelite shoved Moses away and said, 'Who made you our ruler and judge? 28 Are you thinking of killing me, just as you killed the Egyptian yesterday?'[g] 29 When Moses heard that, he escaped and settled as a resident foreigner in Midian, where two sons were born to him.

30 "And after forty years were completed, in the wilderness of Mount Sinai an angel appeared to him in a flaming fire in a thornbush.

31 Moses was amazed at what he saw. As he went closer to get a better look, the Lord's voice spoke:

32 'I am the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.' And Moses, all trembling, did not venture to look closer.

33 And the Lord said to him, 'Untie your sandals from your feet, because holy ground is the place on which you stand.

34 I have seen, I have seen the suffering of my people who are in Egypt, I have heard their groans, and I have come down to deliver them. And now come — I will send you to Egypt.'[h]

35 "This Moses, whom they rejected, saying, 'Who appointed you ruler and judge?' — this one God sent as both ruler and redeemer, with the help of the angel who appeared to him in the bush.

36 This man led them out, doing wonders and signs in Egypt, at the Red Sea,[i] and in the wilderness for forty years.

37 This is that Moses who told the sons of Israel, 'A prophet like me God will raise up for you out of your brothers.'[j]

38 He was among the assembly[k] in the wilderness, with the angel who spoke to him at Mount Sinai and with our ancestors. He received living words to pass on to us.[l]

39 To him our fathers refused to be obedient; they pushed him away, and their hearts turned back toward Egypt,

40 They said to Aaron, ‘Make gods for us who will lead us. As for this
Moses who brought us out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what
has happened to him.’[m]
41 At that time they made an image of a calf, offered a sacrifice to the
idol, and celebrated what their own hands had made.
42 But God turned away and handed them over to worship the host of
heaven, as it is written in the book of the Prophets:
‘Did you offer me slain beasts and sacrifices
forty years in the desert, O house of Israel?
43 You took along the tent of Moloch
and the star of your god Rompha,[n]
images that you made so you could worship them.
Therefore I will remove you to a place beyond Babylon.’[o]
44 “Our fathers had the tent of testimony in the desert, just as he who
spoke to Moses directed him to make it, according to the pattern he
had seen.
45 This tent our fathers, receiving it in their turn, brought in with
Joshua[p] when they took possession of the nations whom God thrust
out before our fathers’ faces; and it remained until the time of David,
46 who won favor before God and asked leave to find a dwelling for
the God of Jacob.[q]
47 Yet a house for him was built by Solomon.
48 But the Most High does not live in what is made by hands; as the
prophet says,
49 ‘Heaven is my throne,
and the earth is my footstool.
What kind of house could you build for me? says the Lord.
Or where would my resting place be?
50 Did not my hand make all these things?’[r]
51 “You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you are
always resisting the Holy Spirit; as your fathers did, so do you. 52 Was
there a prophet your fathers did not hound? They put to death those
who foretold the Righteous One’s coming, of whom you have now
become the betrayers and murderers — 53 you who received the Law
as ordained by angels,[s] and did not keep it.”

54 When they heard these things they were cut to the heart,[t] and they
ground their teeth at him. 55 But he, full of the Holy Spirit, gazed into
heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right
hand of God, 56 and he said, "Look, I see the heavens opened, and the
Son of Man standing at the right hand of God." 57 But they cried out
with a loud voice, stopped their ears, and rushed at him with one
accord. 58 They cast him out of the city and began to stone him; and
the witnesses laid down their garments at the feet of a young man
named Saul.[u] 59 And they went on stoning Stephen as he called out,
"Lord Jesus, receive my spirit." 60 And kneeling down, he called out
in a great voice, "Lord, do not count this sin against them." And with
these words he fell asleep.[v]

Notes

- a (7:2) Haran: in northern Mesopotamia; compare Gen 11:31–12:4.
- b (7:3) Gen 12:1.
- c (7:7) Gen 15:13–14, with Exod 3:12.
- d (7:14) Seventy-five persons: so the Greek Old Testament of Gen 46:27 and Exod 1:5; the Hebrew text has seventy.
- e (7:16) The account combines Abraham's purchase at Hebron (Gen 23:16–20) with Jacob's purchase at Shechem from the sons of Hamor (Gen 33:19; Josh 24:32).
- f (7:20) Beautiful in God's sight: or "exceedingly fair"; compare Exod 2:2.
- g (7:28) Exod 2:14.
- h (7:34) Exod 3:5–10. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" in 7:31 and 7:33 is Yahweh.
- i (7:36) Red Sea: Greek *erythra thalassa*; the Hebrew is *yam suph*, "Sea of Reeds."
- j (7:37) Deut 18:15. Many later manuscripts add "the Lord" before "God" and "listen to him" at the end.
- k (7:38) Assembly: Greek *ekklēsia*, the word rendered "church" elsewhere.
- l (7:38) To you: many manuscripts read "to us."
- m (7:40) Exod 32:1, 23.
- n (7:43) Rompha: so the Westcott–Hort text; other manuscripts spell the name Rephan, Remphan, or Raiphan. It renders, in the Greek Old Testament, the Hebrew *Kiyyun* (probably the planet Saturn) of Amos 5:26. The name's origin is uncertain.
- o (7:43) Amos 5:25–27 (Greek), with "Babylon" in place of "Damascus."
- p (7:45) Joshua: Greek *Iēsous*, the Greek form of the Hebrew name Joshua, "Yahweh saves."
- q (7:46) God of Jacob: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Alexandrinus and many others; Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and Codex Bezae read "house of Jacob," which NA and SBLGNT print. Compare Ps 132:5.

- r (7:50) Isa 66:1–2. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.
- s (7:53) As ordained by angels: or “by the directions of angels”; compare Gal 3:19; Heb 2:2.
- t (7:54) Cut to the heart: literally “sawn through in their hearts,” as in 5:33.
- u (7:58) Saul: Hebrew *Sha’ul*, “asked for.”
- v (7:60) Fell asleep: that is, died.

Chapter 8

1 And Saul was giving approval to his killing.

And there arose on that day a severe persecution of the church at Jerusalem; and everyone but the apostles was dispersed across the countryside of Judea and Samaria.

2 Devout men buried Stephen and raised a loud lament over him.

3 But Saul was ravaging the church; going in house after house and dragging off both men and women, he would commit them to prison.

4 Those who had been scattered traveled from place to place, spreading the message of the good news. 5 Philip went down to the city[a] of Samaria and began preaching the Messiah to them. 6 And with one mind the crowds paid heed to what Philip said, as they listened and watched the signs he was doing. 7 For from many who had unclean spirits, the spirits came out shrieking with a loud cry, and many paralyzed and lame people were cured. 8 So there was much joy in that city.

9 But a certain man named Simon had for some time been practicing magic in the city and astounding the nation of Samaria, claiming to be someone great. 10 Everyone, from the least to the greatest, gave heed to him and said, “This man is the power of God called Great.” 11 They gave heed to him because for a long time he had amazed them with his magic arts. 12 But when Philip announced the good news of the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, they believed him, and men and women were baptized. 13 Even Simon himself believed; and after his baptism he stayed close to Philip constantly, and watching the signs and great miracles taking place, he was astounded.

14 Now the apostles at Jerusalem, on hearing that the people of Samaria had welcomed God’s word, dispatched Peter and John to them. 15 These went down and prayed for them, so that they might

receive the Holy Spirit; 16 since as yet the Spirit had come down on
none of them; they had simply been baptized into the name of the
Lord Jesus. 17 Then they laid their hands on them, and they received
the Holy Spirit. 18 Now when Simon saw that it was through the laying
on of the apostles' hands that the Spirit was given, he offered them
money, 19 and said, "Grant me also this power, so that whoever has
my hands laid on him will receive the Holy Spirit." 20 But Peter said
to him, "May your silver perish along with you, because you thought
the gift of God could be bought with money! 21 In this word you have
neither portion nor lot,[b] because before God your heart is not upright.
22 So turn from this evil of yours, and plead with the Lord in the hope
that the purpose in your heart might perhaps be pardoned. 23 For I see
that you are in the gall of bitterness[c] and the bond of wrongdoing." 24
Simon replied, "Please pray to the Lord for me, so that nothing you
have said will come upon me."[d]
25 So when they had borne their witness and declared the Lord's word,
they made their way back toward Jerusalem, and in many Samaritan
villages they announced the gospel.
26 And the Lord's angel spoke to Philip: "Rise and make your way
southward[e] along the road running down from Jerusalem to Gaza." (It
is a desert road.)[f]
27 He rose and went. And there was a man of Ethiopia,[g] a eunuch, a
high officer under the Candace,[h] the Ethiopians' queen, set over her
entire treasure, who had made the journey to Jerusalem to worship
28 and was returning, seated in his chariot and reading the prophet
Isaiah.
29 The Spirit said to Philip, "Go up and stay close to that chariot."
30 So Philip ran up and heard him reading Isaiah the prophet, and
asked, "Do you really understand what you are reading?"
31 "How could I," he replied, "without someone to lead me in it?" And
he begged Philip to climb up and sit beside him.
32 The passage of Scripture he was reading said:

"He was led like a sheep to be slaughtered,
and like a lamb that is silent before its shearer,
he does not open his mouth.

33 In his humiliation justice was denied him.[i]
Who will tell of his generation?
For his life is taken away from the earth."[j]
34 And the eunuch said to Philip in reply, "Tell me, please: about whom
does the prophet say this — about himself, or about someone else?"
35 Then Philip began to speak, and starting from this very Scripture
he proclaimed Jesus to him.
36 As they went along the road they came to some water, and the
eunuch said, "Look, here is water! What prevents me from being
baptized?"
37 [k]
38 He gave an order to stop the chariot. Then Philip and the eunuch
both went down into the water, and Philip baptized him.
39 When they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord snatched
Philip away,[l] and the eunuch saw him no more, for he went on his
way rejoicing.
40 But Philip found himself at Azotus,[m] and passing through he
preached the good news in all the towns until he came to Caesarea.

Notes

- a (8:5) The city: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts; many others read "a city." The city may be Sebaste, the old capital Samaria.
- b (8:21) Matter: literally "word."
- c (8:23) Gall of bitterness: compare Deut 29:18 (Greek).
- d (8:24) Codex Bezae adds that Simon "did not stop weeping profusely."
- e (8:26) Toward the south: or "at noon" (*kata mesēmbrian*).
- f (8:26) This is a desert road: or "This city is deserted," referring to Gaza.
- g (8:27) Ethiopian: from Greek *Aithiops*, "burnt-face"; here the kingdom of Meroë on the upper Nile, south of Egypt.
- h (8:27) Candace: a title of the queen mother of Ethiopia, not a personal name.
- i (8:33) Justice was denied him: literally "his judgment was taken away."
- j (8:33) Isa 53:7–8 (Greek).
- k (8:37) The earliest and most important manuscripts do not include verse 37; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Some later manuscripts, mostly of the Western type, add, "And Philip said, 'If you believe with all your heart, you may.' And he replied, 'I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.'" The verse is not in the Byzantine majority text, but entered the printed editions from Erasmus.

- l (8:39) Snatched Philip away: Codex Alexandrinus and some others read, "the Holy Spirit fell upon the eunuch, and an angel of the Lord snatched Philip away."
- m (8:40) Azotus: the Philistine city Ashdod.

Chapter 9

1 Meanwhile Saul, still breathing threats and murder against the
disciples of the Lord, went to the high priest 2 and requested from
him letters addressed to the synagogues in Damascus, so that any
he should find who were of the Way, men or women, he could lead
bound to Jerusalem. 3 As he traveled and was approaching Damascus,
suddenly a light out of heaven flashed all around him. 4 Falling to the
ground, he heard a voice saying to him, "Saul, Saul,[a] why are you
persecuting me?" 5 He asked, "Who are you, Lord?" And he said, "I
am Jesus, whom you are persecuting.[b] 6 But rise and go into the city,
and you will be told what you must do." 7 The men traveling with him
stood there speechless, hearing the voice but seeing no one. 8 Saul
rose from the ground, yet with his eyes open he saw nothing; and
taking him by the hand they guided him into Damascus. 9 For three
days he was without sight, and he neither ate nor drank.
10 Now there was a disciple at Damascus named Ananias. The Lord
said to him in a vision, "Ananias." And he said, "Here I am, Lord."
11 And the Lord told him, "Rise, go to the street they call Straight, and
inquire in the house of Judas after one Saul, from Tarsus; for he is
at prayer,
12 and he has seen [in a vision] a man by the name of Ananias entering
and placing his hands upon him, that his sight might return."
13 But Ananias replied, "Lord, many have told me of this man and of
all the evil things he did to your holy ones[c] in Jerusalem;
14 and here he holds authority from the chief priests to bind all who
call on your name."
15 But the Lord said to him, "Go, for this man is a vessel of my choosing,
to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the sons of Israel.
16 For I myself will show him all that he is bound to suffer on behalf
of my name."

17 So Ananias went off to that house. Laying his hands on Saul, he said,
"Brother Saul, I am sent by the Lord, by Jesus himself, who appeared
to you along the road you took here. He wants you to see again and
to be filled with the Holy Spirit."
18 And at once there fell from his eyes what looked like scales, and his
sight came back; he rose and was baptized,
19 and after taking food he was strengthened.

For some days he was with the disciples in Damascus,
20 and immediately in the synagogues he began proclaiming Jesus,
that he is the Son of God.
21 And all his hearers were astonished, saying, "Isn't this the one who
brought havoc in Jerusalem upon those calling on this name? And
didn't he come here just to take them in chains to the chief priests?"
22 But Saul kept growing stronger, and threw the Jews dwelling in
Damascus into confusion, showing for certain that this one is the
Messiah.
23 After many days had gone by, the Jews plotted together to kill him,
24 But Saul came to know of their plan. Day and night they kept watch
even on the gates, so as to do away with him; 25 but his disciples
took him by night and let him down through an opening in the wall,[d]
lowering him in a basket.
26 On reaching Jerusalem he tried to associate with the disciples. Yet
every one of them feared him, because they could not believe he was
truly a disciple. 27 Barnabas, however, took Saul to the apostles. He
explained how Saul had seen the Lord on the road, how the Lord had
spoken to him, and how in Damascus he had preached boldly in the
name of Jesus. 28 So he was with them, going in and out at Jerusalem,
speaking boldly in the name of the Lord. 29 He was speaking and
debating with the Hellenists; but they were attempting to kill him. 30
When the brothers learned of it, they brought him down to Caesarea
and sent him off to Tarsus.
31 Meanwhile the church in all of Judea, Galilee, and Samaria had a
period of calm. It grew stronger and, as people lived in awe of the
Lord and were encouraged by the Holy Spirit, it kept increasing in
numbers.

32 As Peter traveled around the country, he went to visit God's holy
people who lived in Lydda. 33 And he came upon a man there named
Aeneas, who had lain on a cot for eight years, being paralyzed. 34
And Peter said to him, "Aeneas, Jesus Christ heals you; get up and
make your bed."[e] And immediately he got up. 35 And everyone living
in Lydda and in Sharon saw him, and they turned to the Lord.
36 And there lived in Joppa a certain disciple, Tabitha by name, or in
translation, Dorcas.[f] She was rich in good deeds and in the alms she
gave. 37 In those days she fell sick and died; and when they had washed
her, they laid her in an upstairs room. 38 Since Lydda was near Joppa,
the disciples, hearing that Peter was there, sent two men to him to
urge him, "Please come to us without delay." 39 So Peter got up and
accompanied them. On his arrival they brought him up into the upper
room, and all the widows came to stand by him in tears, displaying
the shirts and cloaks Dorcas had sewn while she was still with them. 40
But Peter put them all outside, knelt down and prayed; then, turning
to the body, he said, "Tabitha, get up." And she opened her eyes, and
seeing Peter she sat up. 41 He gave her his hand and raised her up.
Then calling the holy ones and widows, he presented her alive. 42 This
became known throughout all Joppa, and many believed in the Lord.
43 And it came about that he remained a good while in Joppa, with
one Simon, a tanner.

Notes

- a (9:4) Saul: here Greek *Saoul*, the Hebrew form of the name; so also in 9:17.
- b (9:5) Persecuting: some late manuscripts and the Latin Vulgate add here, "It is hard for you to kick against the goads" (compare 26:14), and continue in verse 6, "And trembling and astonished he said, 'Lord, what do you want me to do?' And the Lord said to him." These words are not found in any known Greek manuscript of this passage except as a late correction; they entered the printed editions from Erasmus, who translated them from the Latin.
- c (9:13) Holy ones: or "saints" (*hagioi*), a common name for believers.
- d (9:25) Through an opening in the wall: literally "through the wall"; compare 2 Cor 11:32–33.
- e (9:34) Make your bed: or "prepare a meal for yourself"; literally "spread for yourself."
- f (9:36) Tabitha … Dorcas: both names mean "gazelle," the first in Aramaic, the second in Greek.

Chapter 10

1 There was in Caesarea a man named Cornelius, a centurion[a] of
the cohort known as the Italian Cohort, 2 a devout man who feared
God, as did his whole household; he gave many alms to the people
and prayed to God without ceasing. 3 One afternoon, at about three
o'clock,[b] he clearly saw in a vision an angel of God coming to him
and calling, "Cornelius!" 4 Staring at him in fright, he said, "What is
it, Lord?" And the angel told him, "Your prayers and your alms have
gone up as a memorial before God. 5 Now then, send men to Joppa
and summon one Simon, who is also called Peter. 6 He is lodging with
a certain Simon, a tanner, whose house lies by the sea." 7 When the
angel who had spoken to him was gone, he called two of his house-
hold servants and a devout soldier from among those in attendance
on him, 8 and having explained everything to them, he sent them off
to Joppa.

9 The next day, while they were traveling and approaching the city,
Peter went up on the roof to pray at about noon.[c] 10 He grew hungry
and wanted something to eat; and while it was being made ready, a
trance[d] came over him. 11 He beheld the sky opened and some object
descending, like a great linen sheet, let down by its four corners to
the earth. 12 In it were all kinds of four-footed animals and creeping
things of the earth, and birds of the sky. 13 And there came a voice to
him: "Up, Peter; slaughter and eat." 14 But Peter said, "By no means,
Lord; for never have I eaten anything common[e] or unclean." 15 And
the voice came to him a second time: "What God has made clean, you
must not call common." 16 This happened three times, and at once the
object was taken up into the sky.

17 While Peter was inwardly perplexed as to what the vision he had
seen could mean, look — the men sent by Cornelius, having asked
their way to Simon's house, were standing at the gate.

18 They called out and inquired whether Simon who was called Peter
was staying there as a guest.

19 And as Peter was still turning the vision over in his mind, the Spirit
said, "Look, two[f] men are seeking you.

20 Rise, then, go down, and travel with them, not hesitating at all; for
I have sent them."
21 So Peter went down to the men and said, "Here I am, the man you
are looking for. Why have you come?"
22 They answered, "We come from Cornelius, a centurion. He is an
upright man who worships God and is respected by the whole Jewish
nation. A holy angel instructed him to invite you to his house and
listen to what you have to say."
23 Then Peter called them inside and had them stay as his guests.

On the morrow he got up and went off with them, accompanied
by some of the brothers from Joppa.
24 And the day after that he arrived in Caesarea, where Cornelius was
awaiting them, having invited his kinsmen and his intimate friends
to join him.
25 As Peter was coming in, Cornelius met him, fell at his feet, and paid
him homage.
26 But Peter lifted him up, saying, "Stand up; I too am only a man."
27 And talking with him, he went in and found many gathered,
28 And he told them, "You know well that for a Jewish man to keep
company with a foreigner or to go to his house is forbidden; but God
has shown me to call no person common or unclean.
29 That is why, when I was sent for, I came without objection. So I ask:
for what reason did you send for me?"
30 And Cornelius said, "Four days ago, at this very hour, I was praying
in my house at three in the afternoon;[g] and look, a man in shining
clothing stood before me
31 and said, 'Cornelius, God has listened to your prayer, and he has
called your alms to mind.
32 So send to Joppa and invite Simon, whose other name is Peter, to
come; he is a guest at the house of Simon the tanner beside the sea.'[h]
33 So I sent for you without delay, and you did well to come. And now
all of us are present before God to listen to everything the Lord has
instructed you to say."

34 Then Peter began to speak: “Truly I perceive that God shows no
partiality, 35 rather, whoever in any nation fears him and practices
righteousness is welcome to him. 36 The word he sent to the sons
of Israel, preaching the good news of peace through Jesus Christ —
he is Lord of all —[i] 37 that word you yourselves know, which spread
through all Judea, beginning from Galilee after the baptism that John
proclaimed: 38 You know how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with
the Holy Spirit and power, and how Jesus went around doing good
and healing everyone who was under the devil’s power, because God
was with him. 39 And we are witnesses of all that he did, both in
the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. Him they put to death by
hanging him on a tree; 40 but God raised him on the third day and
granted that he be made manifest, 41 not to all the people, but to
witnesses chosen beforehand by God — to us, who ate and drank with
him after he rose from the dead. 42 And he ordered us to proclaim to
the people and bear solemn witness that this is the one whom God
has ordained to judge both living and dead. 43 All the prophets testify
about him, that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of
sins through his name.”
44 Peter was still uttering these words when the Holy Spirit fell on all
who were listening to the message. 45 And the circumcised believers
who had accompanied Peter were astonished, because upon the
Gentiles as well the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured. 46 for they
heard them speaking in tongues and magnifying God. Then Peter
declared, 47 “Surely no one can refuse the water, that these should not
be baptized, who have received the Holy Spirit as we did?” 48 And he
commanded them to be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ. Then
they asked him to remain for some days.

Notes

- a (10:1) Centurion: a Roman officer in command of about a hundred soldiers.
- b (10:3) About three o’clock one afternoon: literally “about the ninth hour of the day,” the hour of prayer (3:1).
- c (10:9) About noon: literally “about the sixth hour.”
- d (10:10) Trance: Greek *ekstasis*.
- e (10:14) Common: that is, ritually unclean; Greek *koinos*.

- f (10:19) Two: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus; most manuscripts read "three" (compare 11:11), and some omit the number.
- g (10:30) Three in the afternoon: literally "the ninth hour." The Greek of this sentence is difficult; many manuscripts read "Four days ago I was fasting until this hour, and at the ninth hour I was praying."
- h (10:32) By the sea: many later manuscripts add "When he comes he will speak to you."
- i (10:36) The Greek of 10:36–37 is irregular, and the sentence may be read in several ways. Some manuscripts omit "which" (*hon*) in 10:36, making it read, "He sent the word to the sons of Israel."

Chapter 11

1 Now the apostles and the brothers who were throughout Judea
heard that the Gentiles too had received the word of God. 2 So when
Peter went up to Jerusalem, the believers who held to circumcision[a]
criticized him, 3 saying, "You went in to uncircumcised men and ate
with them." 4 But Peter began and set the matter out before them in
order, saying, 5 "I was in the city of Joppa praying, and in a trance I
saw a vision: an object was coming down, like a great sheet lowered
by its four corners out of the sky, and it came right down to me. 6
Gazing into it I looked closely, and I saw four-footed creatures of the
earth, wild beasts, reptiles, and birds of the sky. 7 And I also heard
a voice telling me, 'Up, Peter; slaughter and eat.' 8 But I answered,
'Never, Lord; for nothing common or unclean has once entered my
mouth.' 9 And the voice from the sky answered again: 'The things
God has cleansed, you are not to treat as common.' 10 Three times this
occurred, and then all of it was pulled up again into the sky. 11 And
look, at that moment three men, sent from Caesarea to me, came and
stood before the house in which we were. 12 The Spirit told me to go
with them without hesitating.[b] These six brothers came with me too,
and we went into the man's house. 13 And he reported to us how he
saw the angel stand in his house and say, 'Dispatch men to Joppa and
fetch Simon, surnamed Peter; 14 he will tell you things through which
you and your whole house will be saved.' 15 And when I had begun to
speak, the Holy Spirit came down upon them, even as upon us in the
beginning. 16 Then I recalled what the Lord had said: 'John baptized
with water, whereas you shall be baptized in the Holy Spirit.' 17 So

if God gave them the same gift he gave us when we believed in the Lord Jesus Christ, who was I to stand in God's way?" 18 At hearing this they quieted down, and they gave glory to God: "Then even to the Gentiles God has given the repentance that brings life."

19 Now those who had been scattered by the persecution that began with Stephen traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch, sharing the message only with Jews. 20 Some of them, however, were from Cyprus and Cyrene. When they reached Antioch, they also spoke to the Greek-speaking people,[c] telling them the good news about the Lord Jesus. 21 And the hand of the Lord was with them, and a great number believed and turned to the Lord. 22 News of this came to the ears of the church in Jerusalem, and they sent Barnabas off to Antioch. 23 On arriving he saw the grace that God had given, and he was glad, and he urged everyone to cling to the Lord with a resolute heart; 24 He was a good man, full of the Holy Spirit and faith. And a great many people were brought to the Lord. 25 Then he went off to Tarsus to look for Saul, 26 and when he had found him, he brought him to Antioch. For a whole year they met with the church and taught a large company; and it was in Antioch that the disciples were first called Christians.[d]

27 In these days prophets came down from Jerusalem to Antioch.[e] 28 And one of them, Agabus by name, rose and signified through the Spirit that a great famine was about to come upon the whole world;[f] and it came in the time of Claudius. 29 So the disciples determined, each according to his ability, to send relief to the brothers living in Judea. 30 This they did, sending it to the elders by the hand of Barnabas and Saul.

Notes

- a (11:2) Those of the circumcision: that is, Jewish believers who insisted on circumcision for Gentile converts; or simply "the circumcised believers." Codex Bezae greatly expands 11:1–2, telling how Peter, after long delay, journeyed to Jerusalem teaching along the way.
- b (11:12) Making no distinction: or "without hesitating"; some manuscripts omit the phrase.

- c (11:20) Hellenists: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and most manuscripts; others, including Alexandrinus and Codex Bezae, read "Greeks," which suits the context better and is followed by many translations.
- d (11:26) Christians: Greek *Christianoi*, "partisans of Christ" (*Christos*, "Anointed").
- e (11:27) Antioch: Codex Bezae here begins one of its "we" passages: "and there was great rejoicing; and when we were gathered together, one of them…."
- f (11:28) World: Greek *oikoumenē*, "the inhabited earth," that is, the Roman world. A severe famine struck Judea about AD 46–48.

Chapter 12

1 At about that season Herod the king[a] set his hand to mistreat certain
members of the church. 2 James the brother of John he put to death
with the sword; 3 and when he saw that this pleased the Jews, he
went further and had Peter seized as well. (These were the days of
Unleavened Bread.) 4 After seizing him, Herod put him in prison and
assigned four teams of four soldiers each to guard him. He planned
to bring him out for public trial after the Passover. 5 So Peter was kept
under guard in the prison; but earnest prayer for him was being made
to God by the church. 6 On the very night before Herod was going to
bring him out, Peter lay sleeping between two soldiers, bound with
two chains, while sentries in front of the door kept watch over the
prison. 7 Suddenly an angel of the Lord appeared, and light flooded
the cell. The angel tapped Peter's side to wake him and said, "Hurry,
get up!" And the chains dropped from his hands. 8 The angel said to
him, "Fasten your belt and tie on your sandals." He did so. Then the
angel told him, "Throw your cloak around you and follow me." 9 And
he went out and followed, not knowing that what the angel was doing
was real; he thought he was seeing a vision. 10 They passed the first
guard and then the second, and came to the iron gate to the city. It
swung open for them by itself, and they went out and walked down
one street.[b] Then suddenly the angel left him. 11 Peter then realized
what had happened. He said, "Now I am sure that the Lord sent his
angel and saved me from Herod's power and from everything the
Jewish people were hoping for."
12 When he had grasped this, he went to the house of Mary, the mother
of John whose other name was Mark, where a good number had

gathered and were praying. 13 He knocked at the door of the gateway,
and a servant girl named Rhoda[c] came to answer. 14 She knew Peter's
voice, and for sheer gladness she left the gate unopened, running
inside instead to report that Peter stood outside. 15 "You are out of
your mind," they told her. But she kept insisting it was so. They said,
"It is his angel." 16 Meanwhile Peter kept on knocking; and when they
opened, they saw him and were amazed. 17 Motioning to them with his
hand to be quiet, he related how the Lord had brought him out of the
prison. And he said, "Tell these things to James and to the brothers."
Then he left and went to another place.
18 With the coming of daylight the soldiers were in no little uproar:
what, then, had happened to Peter? 19 Herod searched for him, and
when he could not find him, he examined the guards and ordered
them led away to execution.[d] Then he went down from Judea to
Caesarea and stayed there.
20 Now Herod was bitterly at odds with the Tyrians and Sidonians.
With one accord they presented themselves before him, and once
they had persuaded Blastus, who was over the king's bedchamber,
they sued for peace, since their land was fed from the king's land.
21 On a day fixed beforehand Herod, arrayed in kingly apparel and
seated on the tribunal,[e] made an oration to them. 22 And the populace
kept shouting, "The voice of a god, and not of a man!" 23 Instantly an
angel of the Lord struck him down, because he did not give the glory
to God; and he was eaten by worms and breathed his last.[f]
24 But the word of the Lord kept growing and multiplying. 25 And
Barnabas and Saul returned to[g] Jerusalem when they had fulfilled
their service, bringing with them John whose other name was Mark.

Notes

- a (12:1) Herod the king: Herod Agrippa I, grandson of Herod the Great, king of Judea AD 41–44.
- b (12:10) Street: Codex Bezae adds that they "went down the seven steps."
- c (12:13) Led away to execution: literally "led away," which in this context implies execution.
- d (12:19) Rhoda: "rose."
- e (12:21) Platform: Greek *bēma*, a raised speaker's platform or judgment seat.

- f (12:23) Josephus also records Agrippa's sudden death at Caesarea in AD 44 (*Antiquities* 19.343–50).
- g (12:25) Returned to: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and most manuscripts (literally "returned, to Jerusalem"); because Barnabas and Saul had been sent *to* Jerusalem (11:30), many manuscripts read "from Jerusalem," and some editors join "to Jerusalem" with what follows: "returned, having fulfilled their service in Jerusalem."

Chapter 13

1 There were in Antioch, in the church that was there, prophets and
teachers — Barnabas; Simeon, called Niger;[a] Lucius the Cyrenian;
Manaen, a companion from boyhood of Herod the tetrarch;[b] and
Saul. 2 As they were serving[c] the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit
said, "Separate now to me Barnabas and Saul, for the work I have
summoned them to." 3 So when they had fasted and prayed and placed
their hands upon them, they released them.
4 So these two, sent out by the Holy Spirit, went down to Seleucia,
and from there they sailed off to Cyprus. 5 Arriving at Salamis, they
began announcing the word of God in the synagogues of the Jews;
and they had John as their assistant. 6 Having gone through the whole
island as far as Paphos, they came upon a magician, a Jewish false
prophet whose name was Bar-Jesus.[d] 7 He was in the company of the
proconsul, Sergius Paulus, a man of understanding, who summoned
Barnabas and Saul and sought to hear the word of God. 8 But Elymas
the magician (that is what his name means)[e] stood against them and
tried to keep the proconsul from believing. 9 But Saul, also known
as Paul,[f] filled with the Holy Spirit, fixed his eyes on him 10 and said,
"Full of all trickery and all unscrupulousness, son of the devil, foe of
everything right — will you never cease twisting the Lord's straight
ways? 11 And now, see, the Lord's hand is against you: blind you shall
be, unable for a season to look upon the sun." At once a mist and
a darkness came down on him, and he went about seeking people
to lead him by the hand. 12 Then the proconsul, seeing what had
occurred, believed, struck with astonishment at the teaching about
the Lord.

13 Setting sail from Paphos, Paul and those with him reached Perga
in Pamphylia; John, however, parted from them and went back to
Jerusalem.
14 They went on from Perga and came to Pisidian Antioch;[g] and on
the sabbath day they went into the synagogue and took their seats.
15 Once the Law and the Prophets had been read aloud, the synagogue
rulers sent them a message: "Brothers, if there is among you any word
of encouragement for the people, say it."
16 So Paul stood up and, motioning with his hand, said:
"Men of Israel, and you who fear God,[h] listen.
17 The God of this people Israel chose our fathers, and made the people
great during their sojourn in the land of Egypt, and with an uplifted
arm he led them out of it.
18 For about forty years he put up with them[i] in the desert.
19 He wiped out seven nations in Canaan and distributed their terri-
tory to his people as an inheritance.
20 All this took roughly four hundred fifty years.[j] Afterward he pro-
vided judges for them, until the time of the prophet Samuel.
21 Then they asked for a king, and God gave them Saul the son of Kish,
a man of the tribe of Benjamin, for forty years.
22 After removing Saul, he made David their king. God testified about
him, saying, 'I have found David son of Jesse to be a man who pleases
my heart; he will do everything I want him to do.'[k]
23 God has brought to Israel a Savior, Jesus, from this man's descen-
dants, as he promised.
24 John having first proclaimed, before his coming, a baptism of repen-
tance to all the people of Israel.
25 As John was finishing his work, he used to say, 'Who do you think
I am? I am not the one. But someone is coming after me, and I am not
even worthy to untie his sandals.'
26 "Brothers, sons of the family of Abraham, and those among you
who fear God, to us[l] has the message of this salvation been sent.

27 For those dwelling in Jerusalem and their rulers, in ignorance of
him and of the voices of the prophets read out sabbath after sabbath,
brought those voices to fulfillment by their condemning him.
28 And though they found no ground for a sentence of death, they
asked Pilate to have him executed.
29 When they had carried out everything that was written of him, they
took him down from the tree and laid him in a tomb.
30 But God raised him from the dead,
31 and over a span of many days he was seen by the men who had gone
up with him from Galilee to Jerusalem, who are [now] his witnesses
to the people.
32 And as for us, we announce to you as good news the promise made
to the fathers,
33 that this promise God has fully kept for us, their children,[m] in raising
up Jesus, just as the second psalm[n] has it written:

'You are my Son;
today I have begotten you.'[o]

34 That he raised him up from among the dead, never again to go back
to corruption, he declared thus: 'I will give you the holy things of
David, the trustworthy ones.'[p]
35 Therefore he also says in another psalm, 'You will not let your Holy
One see decay.'[q]
36 For David, when in his own generation he had ministered to God's
purpose, fell asleep, was gathered to his fathers, and saw corruption;
37 but he whom God raised saw no corruption.
38 Be it known to you, then, brothers, that through this one release
from sins is being announced to you,
39 and that by him everyone who believes is set free[r] from all the things
from which you could not be set free by the Law of Moses.
40 Take care that what the prophets said does not happen to you:
41 'See, you despisers, and marvel, and vanish away;
for a deed I am doing in your days,
a deed you will by no means believe, though one should recount
it to you.'"[s]

42 As they were leaving, people[t] kept pleading that on the sabbath next
following these words be spoken to them again.
43 When the synagogue gathering had dispersed, many Jews and
devout converts went after Paul and Barnabas, who talked with them
and persuaded them to abide in God's grace.
44 The sabbath after, nearly all the city came together to listen to the
Lord's word.[u]
45 But when the Jews saw the crowds, they were filled with jealousy,
and they contradicted what Paul was saying, reviling him.
46 Then Paul and Barnabas, speaking with all boldness, declared, "To
you first the word of God had to be spoken. But since you push it
away and reckon yourselves undeserving of life eternal, see, we turn
now to the Gentiles.
47 For this is the Lord's command to us:
'I have made you a light of the nations,
that you should be for salvation to the farthest end of the earth.'"[v]
48 When the Gentiles heard this, they began rejoicing and glorifying
the word of God,[w] and as many as had been appointed to eternal life
believed.
49 And the Lord's word was carried through all that country.
50 But the Jews worked upon the God-fearing women of rank and
the foremost men of the town, raised a persecution against Paul and
Barnabas, and threw them out of their borders.
51 But they shook off the dust of their feet against them and went to
Iconium.
52 And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit.

Notes

- a (13:1) Niger: Latin, "black."
- b (13:1) Herod the tetrarch: Herod Antipas, ruler of Galilee and Perea (Luke 3:1); "brought up with" may mean "foster brother of" or "companion at court of."
- c (13:2) Worshiping: Greek *leitourgountōn*, "serving, ministering."
- d (13:6) Bar-Jesus: Aramaic, "son of Jesus (Joshua)."
- e (13:8) That is how his name is translated: the connection between "Elymas" and "magician" is uncertain; the name may come from an Aramaic or Arabic word for "sage" or "sorcerer." Codex Bezae reads "Etoimas."
- f (13:9) Paul: Latin *Paulus*, "small"; from here on Luke uses Saul's Roman name.

- g (13:14) Pisidian Antioch: literally “Antioch the Pisidian,” a city on the border of Pisidia in the Roman province of Galatia, distinct from Antioch in Syria.
- h (13:16) You who fear God: Gentiles who worshiped the God of Israel without becoming full proselytes.
- i (13:18) Put up with them: so the Westcott–Hort text (*etropophorēsen*); other manuscripts read *etrophophorēsen*, “cared for them.” Compare Deut 1:31 (Greek).
- j (13:20) About four hundred and fifty years: probably the 400 years in Egypt, 40 in the desert, and the period of the conquest. Many later manuscripts place this phrase after “And after that,” making it the period of the judges.
- k (13:22) Ps 89:20; 1 Sam 13:14; Isa 44:28.
- l (13:26) To us: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts; many manuscripts read “to you.”
- m (13:33) For us, their children: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the earliest manuscripts (literally “for our children”); many later manuscripts read “for us their children.” Some editions begin verse 33 at “this he has fulfilled,” as here; others, at “as also it is written.”
- n (13:33) The second psalm: Codex Bezae reads “the first psalm,” reflecting an ancient practice of counting Psalms 1 and 2 as one.
- o (13:33) Ps 2:7.
- p (13:34) Isa 55:3 (Greek).
- q (13:35) Ps 16:10 (Greek Ps 15:10).
- r (13:39) Set free: Greek *dikaioutai*, “is justified, is acquitted.”
- s (13:41) Hab 1:5 (Greek).
- t (13:42) The people: literally “they.” Many later manuscripts read, “As the Jews went out of the synagogue, the Gentiles begged.”
- u (13:44) Of the Lord: many manuscripts read “of God.”
- v (13:47) Isa 49:6. In the Hebrew text this is said to the Servant of Yahweh.
- w (13:48) Of God: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and Codex Bezae; many manuscripts read “of the Lord.”

Chapter 14

1 In Iconium it happened likewise: they entered the synagogue of
the Jews and so spoke that a great multitude, Jews and Greeks alike,
came to faith. 2 But the Jews who would not be persuaded[a] roused
the minds of the Gentiles and poisoned them against the brothers.
3 So they stayed there for a considerable time, speaking boldly and
trusting in the Lord. He supported the message of his grace by letting
them perform signs and wonders. 4 And the population of the city
was split: some sided with the Jews, some with the apostles. 5 When a
move was afoot among Gentiles and Jews, together with their rulers,

to abuse them and stone them, 6 they learned of it and fled for refuge
to the Lycaonian towns of Lystra and Derbe and the country round
about, 7 and there they went on telling the good news.[b]
8 Now at Lystra a certain man sat who had no strength in his feet,
lame since his mother's womb, one who had never walked. 9 This man
was listening as Paul spoke; and Paul, looking at him intently and
seeing that he had faith to be made well, 10 and shouted, "Get up and
stand on your feet!" At that, the man sprang up and started walking
around. 11 When the crowds saw what Paul had done, they lifted up
their voices, crying in Lycaonian, "The gods have come down to us
in human likeness!" 12 Barnabas they called Zeus, and Paul Hermes,[c]
since it was he who led in speaking. 13 And the priest of Zeus, whose
temple stood before the city,[d] brought bulls and garlands to the gates
and with the crowds was ready to offer sacrifice. 14 When the apostles
Barnabas and Paul heard about this, they tore their clothes and ran
into the crowd, shouting, 15 "Men, why are you doing this? We too are
mortals, with feelings like your own, and we bring you good news:
that from these empty things you should turn to a living God, who
made heaven and earth and sea and everything in them. 16 In the
generations gone by he let all the nations go their own ways; 17 and yet
he did not leave himself without witness, for he did you good — giving
you rains from heaven and fruitful seasons, filling your hearts with
food and gladness." 18 Even with these words they barely restrained
the crowds from sacrificing to them.
19 But Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium, and having won the
crowds over, they stoned Paul and dragged him outside the city,
supposing him dead. 20 But the disciples formed a circle about him,
and he rose and walked back into the town; and the next day he left
with Barnabas for Derbe.
21 After evangelizing that town and making a good many disciples,
they retraced their way to Lystra, Iconium, and Antioch, 22 strength-
ening the souls of the disciples, encouraging them to hold fast to the
faith, and telling them that it is through many afflictions that we must
enter the kingdom of God. 23 They chose[e] elders for them church by
church, and after praying and fasting they committed them to the

Lord on whom their faith rested. 24 Then they traveled through Pisidia
and reached Pamphylia; 25 and after speaking the word in Perga, they
went down to Attalia. 26 Thence they sailed off to Antioch, the place
where they had first been handed over to God's grace for the task
that they had now fulfilled. 27 On arriving, they assembled the church
and told them all that God had accomplished through them, and how
he had opened the door of faith to the Gentiles. 28 And they spent no
little time with the disciples.

Notes

- a (14:2) Who would not be persuaded: or "who disobeyed"; Greek *apeithēsantes*. Codex Bezae expands 14:2, saying that the synagogue leaders stirred up persecution, "but the Lord soon gave peace."
- b (14:7) Codex Bezae adds that the whole populace was stirred by the teaching, and that Paul and Barnabas stayed on in Lystra.
- c (14:12) Zeus ... Hermes: chief of the Greek gods, and the messenger of the gods. A local legend told of Zeus and Hermes visiting this region in human form.
- d (14:13) Whose temple stood before the city: literally "of Zeus who was before the city," a title of the god of the shrine outside the gates.
- e (14:23) Appointed: Greek *cheirotonēsantes*, originally "electing by a show of hands," but by this time also "appointing."

Chapter 15

1 Some men came down from Judea and kept teaching the brothers,
"Unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you
cannot be saved."[a] 2 And when Paul and Barnabas had come into no
small dissension and debate with them, it was arranged that Paul
and Barnabas and certain others of their number should go up to
Jerusalem, to the apostles and elders, about this question. 3 So, sent
on their way by the church, they passed through both Phoenicia and
Samaria, telling in full of the conversion of the Gentiles, and brought
great joy to all the brothers. 4 On their arrival in Jerusalem the church,
the apostles, and the elders received them, and they told over every-
thing God had accomplished with them. 5 Some, however, from the
Pharisees' sect who had come to believe stood up and declared, "They
must be circumcised, and charged to observe Moses' Law."
6 So the apostles and elders met together to consider this question. 7
After a long discussion, Peter stood up and told them, "Brothers, you

know that some time ago God chose me from among you to bring the message of the gospel to the Gentiles, so that they would hear it and believe. 8 And God, the knower of hearts, testified for them, granting them the Holy Spirit even as he granted him to us; 9 and he set no difference at all between them and us, when by faith he purified their hearts. 10 Now, then, why are you putting God to the test by laying on the neck of the disciples a yoke that neither our fathers nor we have had strength to bear? 11 No — it is through the grace of the Lord Jesus that we believe we are saved, in the same way as they."

12 The whole assembly fell silent, and they listened while Barnabas and Paul related what signs and wonders God had done among the Gentiles through them.

13 After they finished speaking, James answered, "Brothers, hear me.
14 Simeon[b] has related how God first took thought to take from among the Gentiles a people for his name.
15 With this the words of the prophets agree, as it stands written,
16 'After this I will return,
and I will rebuild the fallen tent of David;
its ruins I will rebuild,
and I will set it upright again,
17 that those remaining of mankind may search out the Lord,
and every nation upon whom my name is called,
says the Lord, who does these things,
18 known from of old.'[c]

19 My judgment, therefore, is that we should not make trouble for those among the Gentiles who are turning to God,
20 but should write to them to keep away from the pollutions of idols and from sexual immorality and from what is strangled and from blood.[d]
21 For Moses has had people preaching his Law in every city since ancient times, and it is read aloud in the synagogues every Sabbath."

22 Then the apostles and elders, with the agreement of the whole church, chose men from among their own number to send to Antioch along with Paul and Barnabas. They were Judas, called Barsabbas,[e] and Silas,[f] two men who held leading positions among the believers.

23 with this letter in their hand:[g]

"The apostles and the elders, your brothers, to the brothers of Gentile origin in Antioch and Syria and Cilicia: greetings.
24 Since we have heard that certain persons from among us, to whom we gave no instructions, have unsettled you with words, upsetting your minds,[h]
25 we have resolved, having come to one mind, to choose men and send them to you along with our beloved Barnabas and Paul,
26 men who have handed over their lives for the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.
27 We have therefore sent Judas and Silas, who will tell you the same things by word of mouth.
28 For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay upon you no further burden than these necessary things:
29 keep away from food offered to idols, from blood, from things strangled, and from fornication. Guard yourselves against these and it will be well with you.[i] Be strong in health."
30 So when they had been sent off, they went down to Antioch, and having gathered the assembly together, they delivered the letter. 31 And when they had read it, they rejoiced at the encouragement. 32 And Judas and Silas, who were themselves also prophets, encouraged the brothers with many words and strengthened them. 33 And when they had passed some time there, the brothers released them with a blessing of peace to return to the ones who sent them. 34 [j] 35 But Paul and Barnabas stayed on in Antioch, teaching and proclaiming, with many others also, the word of the Lord.
36 Some days later Paul told Barnabas, "We should return and check on the believers in every town where we announced the word of the Lord, to find out how they are doing." 37 Barnabas wanted to take along with them John also, who was called Mark. 38 Paul, however, did not consider it fitting to bring along the man who had deserted them back in Pamphylia and had not stayed with them for the work. 39 And there arose a sharp disagreement, so that they parted company; Barnabas took Mark and sailed off to Cyprus, 40 but Paul chose Silas

and departed, commended by the brothers to the grace of the Lord.[k] 41 And he went through Syria and Cilicia, strengthening the churches.

Notes

- a (15:1) Codex Bezae adds "and walk according to the custom of Moses," and in 15:2 says that Paul had told them to remain as they were when they believed.
- b (15:14) Simeon: Peter's Hebrew name, Shimon, "he has heard."
- c (15:18) Amos 9:11–12 (Greek), with Isa 45:21. The Hebrew of Amos 9:12 reads "that they may possess the remnant of Edom." For "known from of old," many later manuscripts read "Known to God from of old are all his works."
- d (15:20) The Western text (Codex Bezae and others) omits "what is strangled" here and in 15:29, and adds the negative Golden Rule: "and not to do to others what they would not want done to themselves." This turns the decree from food laws into moral precepts (idolatry, immorality, bloodshed).
- e (15:22) Barsabbas: probably "son of the sabbath"; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (15:22) Silas: a Semitic name, perhaps from Aramaic *sheila*, "asked"; Paul calls him Silvanus (1 Thess 1:1). The meaning is uncertain.
- g (15:23) With this letter in their hand: literally "having written by their hand."
- h (15:24) Many later manuscripts add "saying, 'You must be circumcised and keep the Law.'"
- i (15:29) You will do well: Codex Bezae adds "being borne along by the Holy Spirit."
- j (15:34) Verse 34: the Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts do not include verse 34; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Some manuscripts, including Codex Bezae and Ephraemi, add "But it seemed good to Silas to remain there," and Bezae continues, "and Judas journeyed alone." The addition explains why Silas is in Antioch in 15:40.
- k (15:40) Of the Lord: many manuscripts read "of God."

Chapter 16

1 He arrived too at Derbe, and at Lystra. A certain disciple was there by the name of Timothy,[a] whose mother was a believing Jewess, while his father was Greek. 2 The brothers in Lystra and Iconium gave a good report of him. 3 Paul wanted him to go with him; and he took him and circumcised him on account of the Jews who were in those places, for they all knew that his father was a Greek. 4 As they traveled from town to town, they passed on to the believers the decisions made by the apostles and elders in Jerusalem, for them to follow. 5 So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew in numbers daily. 6 They went through the region of Phrygia and Galatia,[b] having been forbidden by the Holy Spirit to speak the word in Asia.[c] 7 When they

had come opposite Mysia, they tried to go into Bithynia, but the Spirit of Jesus[d] did not allow them. 8 So, passing by Mysia, they went down to Troas. 9 And a vision appeared to Paul in the night: a man of Macedonia was standing there, pleading with him and saying, "Cross over into Macedonia and help us." 10 As soon as Paul had seen the vision, we[e] tried to find passage to Macedonia, since we were sure that God had called us to give them the good news.

11 Setting sail, then, from Troas, we ran a straight course to Samothrace, and the following day to Neapolis, 12 and thence to Philippi, foremost city of that part of Macedonia,[f] a Roman colony. Some days we spent in this city. 13 And on the sabbath day we went outside the gate beside a river, where we supposed there was a place of prayer;[g] and sitting down, we spoke to the women who had come together. 14 Among our hearers was a God-fearing woman by the name of Lydia,[h] a seller of purple goods, from the city of Thyatira, whose heart the Lord opened to give heed to Paul's words. 15 And when she had been baptized, and her household, she urged us, saying, "If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come into my house and stay." And she prevailed on us.

16 Once, on our way to the place of prayer, we encountered a slave girl possessed by a spirit of divination,[i] who by her soothsaying brought her masters large profits. 17 She followed Paul and the rest of us, shouting, "These men are servants of the Most High God, and they are telling you how to be saved." 18 This she kept doing for many days. Paul, greatly annoyed, turned and said to the spirit, "I command you in the name of Jesus Christ to come out of her." And it came out that very hour.

19 Her masters, seeing that the hope of their profits had departed, laid hold of Paul and Silas and hauled them to the marketplace in front of the authorities. 20 And having brought them to the magistrates,[j] they said, "These men are throwing our city into an uproar. They are Jews, 21 and they teach practices that we, being Romans, are not permitted to adopt or to observe." 22 The mob also rose up together against them, and the magistrates ripped their clothes from them and ordered them flogged with rods. 23 After beating them severely, they threw them into

prison and told the jailer to guard them carefully. 24 He, on receiving
an order like this, cast them into the innermost cell and made their
feet fast in the wooden stocks.
25 About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to
God, and the prisoners were listening to them, 26 and suddenly there
was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were
shaken; and [immediately] all the doors were opened, and everyone's
bonds were unfastened. 27 When the jailer woke and saw the prison
doors open, he drew his sword and was about to kill himself, suppos-
ing that the prisoners had escaped. 28 But Paul called out with a loud
voice, "Do yourself no harm, for we are all here." 29 Calling for lights,
the jailer sprang inside and, quaking, threw himself down before Paul
and Silas. 30 Then he brought them out and said, "Sirs, what must I
do to be saved?" 31 And they said, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you
will be saved, you and your household." 32 And they spoke the word
of the Lord[k] to him and to all who were in his house. 33 And taking
them at that hour of the night, he bathed the stripes from their backs;
and immediately he was baptized, he and all who were his. 34 Then,
leading them up into his home, he spread a table before them, and
with all his house he was full of joy at having come to believe in God.
35 But when it was day, the magistrates sent the police[l] with the
message, "Let those men go." 36 And the jailer reported these words
to Paul: "The magistrates have sent word to let you go. So come out
now and go in peace." 37 But Paul answered them, "Without a trial
they flogged us in public, Roman citizens though we are, and cast us
into prison — and are they now to put us out quietly? Not at all! Let
them come in person and escort us out." 38 The police reported these
words to the magistrates, and they were afraid when they heard that
they were Roman citizens. 39 So they came and pleaded with them,
and bringing them out, they begged them to depart from the city.[m] 40
After leaving the prison, they went to Lydia's house. There they met
with the believers and encouraged them, and then they left.

Notes

- a (16:1) Timothy: Greek, "honoring God."
- b (16:6) The region of Phrygia and Galatia: or "Phrygia and the Galatian region."

- c (16:6) Asia: the Roman province in western Asia Minor.
- d (16:7) The Spirit of Jesus: this unusual expression is in the earliest manuscripts; later manuscripts read simply "the Spirit."
- e (16:10) We: here the first of the "we" passages in Acts begins (16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16), traditionally taken to mean the author joined Paul.
- f (16:12) A leading city of the district of Macedonia: so the Westcott–Hort text (literally "first city of the part of Macedonia"); the Greek is difficult, and some editors adopt a conjectural reading, "a city of the first district of Macedonia." Macedonia was divided into four districts.
- g (16:13) Place of prayer: Greek *proseuchē*, often used of a synagogue.
- h (16:14) Lydia: a name meaning "the Lydian woman"; Thyatira was in the region of Lydia.
- i (16:16) A spirit of divination: literally "a spirit, a python," after the serpent Python of the oracle at Delphi.
- j (16:20) Magistrates: Greek *stratēgoi*, the chief officials of the colony.
- k (16:32) Police: Greek *rhabdouchoi*, "rod-bearers," the attendants of the magistrates (Latin *lictores*).
- l (16:35) Of the Lord: some early manuscripts read "of God."
- m (16:39) Codex Bezae greatly expands 16:35–40: the magistrates come "to the market place" and, "remembering the earthquake," are afraid; they beg Paul and Silas, "We did not know the truth about you, that you are righteous men," and ask them to leave lest the crowd turn on them again.

Chapter 17

1 Taking the road through Amphipolis and Apollonia, they arrived at
Thessalonica, where the Jews had a synagogue. 2 Paul, as his habit
was, went in among them, and over three sabbaths he reasoned
with them out of the Scriptures, 3 He explained and showed that the
Messiah had to suffer and rise from the dead. "This Jesus I am telling
you about," he said, "is the Messiah." 4 Some of them were convinced
and threw in their lot with Paul and Silas, as did a great crowd of
God-fearing Greeks and not a few of the foremost women. 5 But the
Jews grew jealous, and taking along some wicked fellows from the
marketplace rabble, they gathered a mob and set the city in an uproar.
They descended on Jason's[a] house, seeking to bring Paul and Silas
out to the people's assembly.[b] 6 Not finding them there, they dragged
Jason and certain brothers before the city officials,[c] bawling out,
"These men who have turned the world upside down have come here
too, 7 and Jason has taken them in! They all act against the decrees

of Caesar, saying there is another king, Jesus." [8] At these words both
the crowd and the politarchs became agitated; [9] and only after taking
security from Jason and the others did they let them go.
[10] Immediately, under cover of night, the brothers sent Paul and Silas
away to Beroea, and on their arrival there they went off to the
synagogue of the Jews. [11] These Jews were of nobler mind than those
in Thessalonica: they took in the word with all eagerness, sifting the
Scriptures day after day to see whether these things held true. [12] Many
of them, therefore, became believers, along with no small number
of Greek women of standing and of men. [13] But once the Jews of
Thessalonica learned that the word of God had been proclaimed by
Paul in Beroea too, there also they came, agitating and stirring up the
crowds. [14] Then the brothers at once sent Paul off to make his way to
the sea, while Silas and Timothy stayed behind there. [15] Those who
escorted Paul brought him as far as Athens; and with instructions for
Silas and Timothy to join him with all possible speed, they departed.
[16] Now while Paul waited for them in Athens, his spirit was roused
within him as he saw that the city was full of idols. [17] So he debated
in the synagogue with the Jews and the God-fearing Gentiles, and
daily in the public square with whoever was present. [18] Some of the
Epicurean and Stoic philosophers also engaged him in debate. And
some were saying, "What would this seed-picker[d] wish to say?"
Others, "He seems to be a herald of foreign divinities" — because he
was preaching Jesus and the resurrection.[e] [19] So they took hold of him
and brought him to the Areopagus,[f] saying, "May we learn what this
new teaching is that you are presenting? [20] For you are bringing some
strange notions to our ears; we want, then, to know what these things
mean." [21] (Now all the Athenians and the foreigners residing there had
leisure for nothing else than telling or hearing something newer.)
[22] Paul stood up in front of the Areopagus and said:

"People of Athens, I see that you are very religious in every way.[g]
[23] For as I was passing through and looking over the objects of your
worship, I found also an altar on which had been inscribed, 'To an
unknown god.' What therefore you worship without knowing, this I
announce to you.

24 The God who made the world and all that is in it — he, being Lord
of heaven and earth, does not dwell in shrines made by hands,
25 nor is he waited on by human hands as if he lacked anything, since
he himself gives to all life and breath and all things.
26 And from one[h] he made every nation of humankind to dwell on all
the face of the earth, having fixed appointed seasons and the boundaries of their habitation,
27 God did this so that they would search for him and perhaps reach
out for him and find him, though he is not far from any one of us.
28 'In him we live and move and exist.' As some of your own poets
have said,

'We are also his children.'[i]

29 Being, then, God's offspring, we ought not to think the divine nature
is like gold or silver or stone, a thing engraved by human art and
imagination.
30 God, then, has looked past the times of not knowing; but at present
he is announcing to humanity that everyone in every place must
repent,
31 because he has set a day on which he is about to judge the inhabited
world in righteousness by a man whom he has designated, having
furnished proof to all by raising him from the dead."
32 When they heard about the resurrection of the dead, some of them
mocked, but others said, "We want to hear you again on this topic."
33 So Paul went out from among them. 34 Some people did side with
him and believe. They included Dionysius, who sat on the Areopagus
court,[j] a woman called Damaris,[k] and several others.

Notes

- a (17:5) Jason: a Greek name, "healer," often used by Jews named Joshua (Jesus).
- b (17:5) People's assembly: Greek *dēmos*, the citizen body of a free city; or simply "the crowd."
- c (17:6) City officials: Greek *politarchas*, "politarchs," the title of the magistrates of Thessalonica, attested in inscriptions.
- d (17:18) Seed-picker: Greek *spermologos*, a bird that picks up seeds; used of an idle babbler who picks up scraps of learning.
- e (17:18) Jesus and the resurrection: some hearers may have taken "Resurrection" (*Anastasis*) as the name of a goddess paired with Jesus.

- f (17:19) Areopagus: “hill of Ares,” the Greek god of war; also the name of the council that met there.
- g (17:22) Exceedingly religious: or “very superstitious”; Greek *deisidaimonesterous*.
- h (17:26) From one: many later manuscripts read “from one blood.”
- i (17:28) The words “in him we live and move and have our being” are thought to echo the Cretan poet Epimenides; the quoted line is from Aratus, *Phaenomena* 5.
- j (17:34) Areopagite: a member of the council of the Areopagus.
- k (17:34) Damaris: the meaning is uncertain; perhaps a form of *damalis*, “heifer.” Codex Bezae omits her name.

Chapter 18

1 After this Paul left Athens and came to Corinth. 2 There he came upon a Jew named Aquila,[a] a native of Pontus, lately arrived from Italy with Priscilla[b] his wife because Claudius had ordered all the Jews to leave Rome.[c] He went to see them, 3 and since their craft was his own he lodged with them and they plied it together; tentmaking[d] was their trade. 4 And every sabbath he would argue in the synagogue, trying to persuade Jews and Greeks.

5 When Silas and Timothy arrived from Macedonia, Paul devoted himself fully to preaching, and he declared to the Jews that Jesus was the Messiah. 6 And when they set themselves against him and spoke abusively, he shook out his garments and said to them, “Your blood be on your own heads! I am clean. From now on I will go to the Gentiles.” 7 Moving on from there, he entered the home of one Titius Justus,[e] a God-fearer, whose house stood next door to the synagogue. 8 Crispus,[f] the synagogue ruler, came to believe in the Lord, along with all his household; and many of the Corinthians who heard believed and were baptized. 9 Then the Lord said to Paul one night in a vision, “Have no fear; keep on speaking, and do not be silent, 10 for I am with you, and no one shall lay a hand on you to harm you, because I have many people in this city.” 11 So he settled there a year and six months, teaching the word of God among them.

12 But when Gallio was proconsul of Achaia,[g] the Jews rose up in concert against Paul and brought him before the judgment seat, 13 and charging, “This man is inducing people to revere God against the law.” 14 Paul was about to open his mouth when Gallio said to the Jews, “If it

were some misdeed or vicious crime, O Jews, I would have reason to
bear with you; 15 but if these are questions about words and names and
your own law, see to it yourselves. A judge of such matters I refuse
to be." 16 So he had them driven from the tribunal. 17 Then everyone[h]
grabbed Sosthenes, the leader of the synagogue, and beat him in front
of the judge's seat. But Gallio showed no concern about any of this.
18 Paul remained many days more, then bade the brothers farewell and
set sail for Syria, Priscilla and Aquila with him, having shorn his head
at Cenchreae, since he had taken a vow.[i] 19 They came to Ephesus,
and he left them there; but he himself went into the synagogue and
reasoned with the Jews. 20 They pressed him to remain longer, but he
would not consent; 21 but on taking leave of them he said, "I will come
back to you again, if God wills,"[j] and he set sail from Ephesus. 22 When
he had landed at Caesarea, he went up[k] and greeted the church, and
then went down to Antioch. 23 Having spent a while there, he set out
and passed in turn through the Galatian country and Phrygia, giving
strength to all the disciples.
24 Meanwhile there arrived at Ephesus a certain Jew, Apollos[l] by name,
Alexandrian by birth, a learned man and mighty in the Scriptures. 25
This man had received instruction in the way of the Lord. He was
passionate in spirit, and he taught accurately about Jesus, though the
only baptism he knew was John's. 26 He began to speak out boldly in
the synagogue; but when Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took
him aside and explained to him the Way of God[m] more accurately. 27
He wanted to go across into Achaia, so the brothers urged him on
and wrote asking the disciples to receive him. After he came, he was
of great service to the ones who by grace had come to believe;[n] 28
for with force he confuted the Jews openly, demonstrating from the
Scriptures that the Messiah was Jesus.

Notes

- a (18:2) Aquila: Latin, "eagle."
- b (18:2) Priscilla: a diminutive of the Latin Prisca, "ancient, venerable."
- c (18:2) The emperor Claudius expelled Jews from Rome about AD 49 (Suetonius, *Claudius* 25.4).
- d (18:3) Tentmakers: Greek *skēnopoioi*; possibly "leatherworkers."

- e (18:7) Titius Justus: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus; Sinaiticus reads "Titus Justus," and many manuscripts simply "Justus."
- f (18:8) Crispus: Latin, "curly."
- g (18:12) Gallio … proconsul of Achaia: Lucius Junius Gallio, brother of the philosopher Seneca; an inscription at Delphi places his proconsulship in AD 51–52.
- h (18:17) They all: many later manuscripts read "all the Greeks."
- i (18:18) He was under a vow: probably a Nazirite vow or one like it (Num 6:1–21); grammatically, the one who cut his hair might be Aquila.
- j (18:21) If God wills: many later manuscripts, following Codex Bezae, add before this, "I must by all means keep the coming feast in Jerusalem."
- k (18:22) He went up: that is, to Jerusalem.
- l (18:24) Apollos: short for Apollonius, from the god Apollo.
- m (18:26) The Way of God: some manuscripts read "the Way of the Lord," and others "the Way."
- n (18:27) Codex Bezae rewrites 18:27, saying that some Corinthians staying in Ephesus urged Apollos to come to their country.

Chapter 19

1 It came about, while Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed
through the inland regions,[a] came down to Ephesus, where he found
certain disciples. 2 "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you came to
believe?" he asked them. They replied, "No — we have not so much
as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit." 3 "Into what, then, were you
baptized?" he said. "Into John's baptism," said they. 4 Paul answered,
"John's was a baptism of repentance; he told the people that their
faith must rest on him who was to come after — on Jesus, that is." 5 On
hearing this, they were baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus. 6 And
when Paul had laid his hands upon them, the Holy Spirit came on
them, and they began speaking in tongues and prophesying. 7 There
were about twelve men in all.
8 He went into the synagogue and for three months spoke out boldly,
debating and persuading about the kingdom of God. 9 But when some
grew hardened and would not believe, maligning the Way before the
gathering, he withdrew from them, took the disciples apart with him,
and day by day held discussions in the lecture hall of Tyrannus.[b] 10
This went on for two years, so that every inhabitant of Asia, Jew and
Greek, heard the word of the Lord. 11 And God was working miracles
of no ordinary kind by Paul's hands, 12 so much so that cloths and

aprons[c] were taken from his body to those who were ill, and they were rid of their sicknesses and the wicked spirits departed.
13 Some traveling Jewish exorcists tried to use the name of the Lord Jesus over people who had evil spirits. They said, "I command you in the name of the Jesus that Paul preaches." 14 Seven sons of a certain Sceva, a Jewish high priest,[d] were doing this. 15 But the evil spirit retorted to them, "Jesus I know, and Paul I am acquainted with; but you — who are you?" 16 Then the man in whom the evil spirit was leaped on them, overpowered them both,[e] and so prevailed against them that they fled out of that house naked and wounded. 17 This became known to all the residents of Ephesus, Jews and Greeks alike; fear fell upon them all, and the name of the Lord Jesus was held in high honor. 18 Many of those who had believed now came forward, confessing and disclosing their practices.[f] 19 And a good number of those who had practiced magic arts brought their books together and burned them in the sight of all. When they reckoned up the value of them, it came to fifty thousand days' wages.[g] 20 So mightily did the word of the Lord grow and prevail.
21 When all this was accomplished, Paul purposed in the Spirit[h] to travel by way of Macedonia and Achaia to Jerusalem, saying, "After I have been there, I must see Rome as well." 22 He sent two of his assistants, Timothy and Erastus,[i] to Macedonia, while he himself remained in Asia a little longer.
23 About that time there arose no small disturbance concerning the Way. 24 For a silversmith named Demetrius, who made [silver] shrines of Artemis,[j] was bringing the craftsmen no small business. 25 He gathered them together, along with the workers in similar trades, and said, "Gentlemen, you know that we make a good living from this business. 26 You are looking on and hearing how, not at Ephesus only but over nearly the whole of Asia, this Paul has won over a sizable crowd and led them astray, by telling them that handmade gods are no gods at all. 27 It is not merely this line of ours that risks falling into contempt; the sanctuary of the mighty goddess Artemis also stands to be reckoned as nothing, and she is about to be stripped of her majesty, she whom the whole of Asia and the world revere." 28 When

they heard this, they were filled with rage and kept shouting, “Great
is Artemis of the Ephesians!” 29 So the whole city was filled with
turmoil, and with one impulse they surged into the theater, seizing as
they went Gaius and Aristarchus,[k] Macedonians traveling with Paul.
30 Paul wanted to go in among the people, but the disciples would
not let him; 31 and even some of the officials of the province,[l] who
were friends of his, sent to him and urged him not to venture into
the theater. 32 Now some were crying one thing, some another; the
assembly was a confused mass, and the greater part had no idea for
what purpose they had assembled. 33 Some in the crowd instructed
Alexander, since the Jews had thrust him to the front; and Alexander,
waving his hand for silence, was ready to offer a defense before the
populace. 34 But when they recognized that he was a Jew, a single cry
went up from them all, and for about two hours they kept shouting,
“Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!”
35 The town clerk[m] finally calmed the mob and said, “Ephesians, what
man alive is unaware that Ephesus is guardian of the temple[n] of great
Artemis and of the image fallen from heaven?[o] 36 Since, then, these
things cannot be contradicted, you ought to be quiet and do nothing
rash. 37 For you have brought these men here who are neither temple
robbers nor blasphemers of our goddess. 38 So if Demetrius and his
fellow craftsmen have a case against somebody, court days are held
and proconsuls sit; let the parties bring their accusations there. 39 And
should you want anything beyond that, the matter will be resolved
in the regular assembly. 40 For we are in danger of being charged with
rioting over today’s events, there being no cause that we can give to
account for this commotion.” 41 And when he had said these things,
he dismissed the assembly.

Notes

- a (19:1) The inland regions: literally “the upper parts,” the highlands of Asia Minor. Codex Bezae begins the verse: “But when Paul wished, according to his own plan, to go to Jerusalem, the Spirit told him to return to Asia.”
- b (19:9) Tyrannus: Greek, “tyrant, ruler,” probably the owner of the hall or a teacher who lectured there. Codex Bezae adds “from eleven in the morning until four in the afternoon” (literally “from the fifth hour to the tenth”), the hours of the midday rest.

- c (19:12) Handkerchiefs or aprons: Latin loanwords in Greek, *soudaria* and *simikinthia*; probably sweat cloths and work aprons.
- d (19:14) A Jewish high priest: no Sceva is known among the high priests; he may have been of a high-priestly family or claimed the title.
- e (19:16) Both: or "all of them"; the Greek *amphoterōn* sometimes means "all" in later Greek.
- f (19:18) Practices: Greek *praxeis*, perhaps in the technical sense of magic spells.
- g (19:19) Fifty thousand days' wages: literally "fifty thousand of silver," that is, silver coins, probably drachmas, each roughly a day's wage for a laborer.
- h (19:21) In the Spirit: or "in his spirit."
- i (19:22) Erastus: Greek, "beloved."
- j (19:24) Artemis: the Greek goddess identified with the Roman Diana; the Artemis of Ephesus was a mother goddess whose temple was one of the seven wonders of the world. The shrines were probably small models of the temple.
- k (19:29) Gaius and Aristarchus: Gaius is a common Latin name; Aristarchus, Greek, "best ruler."
- l (19:31) Officials of the province: Greek *Asiarchōn*, "Asiarchs," leading men of the province of Asia.
- m (19:35) Town clerk: Greek *grammateus*, the chief civic official of Ephesus.
- n (19:35) Temple keeper: Greek *neōkoros*, an honorary title of cities that maintained the temple of a deity or of the emperor.
- o (19:35) The sacred stone that fell from the sky: literally "the fallen-from-Zeus [thing]," probably a meteorite venerated as an image of the goddess.

Chapter 20

1 When the uproar had ceased, Paul sent for the disciples and, after
encouraging them, said farewell and set out for Macedonia. 2 When
he had gone through those parts and had given them much encour-
agement, he came to Greece. 3 where he stayed for three months.
Because the Jews plotted against him just as he was about to sail for
Syria, he decided to go back through Macedonia.[a] 4 He was accompa-
nied by Sopater the son of Pyrrhus, of Beroea; of the Thessalonians,
Aristarchus and Secundus; Gaius of Derbe,[b] and Timothy; and from
Asia, Tychicus and Trophimus.[c] 5 These went on ahead and were
waiting for us at Troas; 6 As for us, we set sail out of Philippi once the
days of Unleavened Bread were over, and five days later joined them
in Troas, where we remained a week.
7 On the first day of the week we met to break bread. Paul spoke to
the people, and since he was going to leave the next day, he kept

on talking until midnight. 8 There were many lamps in the upper
room where we were gathered. 9 And a young man named Eutychus,[d]
sitting at the window, was sinking into a deep sleep as Paul talked
still longer. Overcome by sleep, he fell down from the third story[e] and
was picked up dead. 10 Paul, however, went down, flung himself upon
him, and clasping him said, "Stop your lamenting; his life is still in
him." 11 Then he climbed back up, broke the bread, and ate; and after
speaking with them at length, till dawn, he left. 12 And they brought
the lad home living, and were greatly comforted.
13 We, meanwhile, went before him to the ship and put out for Assos,
where we were to pick Paul up; this was his arrangement, as he meant
to make the journey on foot. 14 When he joined us at Assos, we took
him aboard and came to Mitylene. 15 And sailing from there we came
the following day opposite Chios; the next day we touched at Samos;[f]
and the day after that we came to Miletus. 16 For Paul had determined
to sail on past Ephesus and not lose time in Asia; he was pressing on,
if at all possible, to be in Jerusalem for Pentecost day.
17 Now from Miletus he sent to Ephesus and called the elders of the
church to come to him.
18 On their arrival he addressed them:

"You know well what my conduct was with you all along, from the
day I first stepped into Asia:
19 slaving for the Lord in all lowliness of mind, in tears, and in the
testings that came upon me from the Jews' plotting;
20 how I held back nothing that would benefit you, but declared it to
you and taught you openly and in your homes,
21 bearing solemn witness to Jews and Greeks alike of repentance
toward God and faith in our Lord Jesus.[g]
22 And now, see, bound by the Spirit[h] I am on my way to Jerusalem,
unaware of what I shall meet with there,
23 save that city after city the Holy Spirit warns me solemnly that
chains and hardships lie in wait for me.
24 Yet I hold my life worth nothing, not precious to me at all, so long
as I complete my race and the service the Lord Jesus entrusted to me,
of bearing witness to the good news of God's grace.[i]

25 And now, see, this I know: you will none of you look upon my face
again — you all, among whom I went about heralding the kingdom.
26 For that reason I solemnly declare to you on this very day: I am
clean of everyone's blood,
27 for I did not shrink from declaring to you the whole counsel of God.
28 Keep watch over yourselves and over all the flock that the Holy
Spirit has put in your care as overseers.[j] Be shepherds of the church
of God,[k] which he bought with his own blood.[l]
29 I know that once I have gone, savage wolves will make their way
in among you and will not spare the flock;
30 yes, out of your own number men will rise up uttering perversions,
so as to lure the disciples away after themselves.
31 Keep awake, then, and remember that for a three-year stretch, by
night and by day, I never stopped warning each of you, with tears.
32 And now I commend you to the Lord[m] and to the word of his grace,
which is able to build you up and to give you the inheritance among
all those who are sanctified.
33 I coveted no one's silver or gold or apparel.
34 You know very well that I worked with my own hands to meet my
needs and the needs of my companions.
35 In everything I have given you an example: that toiling thus we
ought to come to the aid of the weak, keeping in mind the saying of
the Lord Jesus himself, 'More blessed is giving than receiving.'"[n]
36 And when he had said these things, he knelt down and prayed with
them all. 37 They all wept freely, and falling on Paul's neck they kissed
him again and again, 38 grieved above all at the word he had said, that
they were never more to see his face. Then they went with him down
to the ship.

Notes

- a (20:3) Codex Bezae reads, "he wished to sail to Syria, but the Spirit told him to return through Macedonia."
- b (20:4) Gaius of Derbe: Codex Bezae reads "Gaius of Doberus," a town in Macedonia, which would make him the Macedonian Gaius of 19:29.
- c (20:4) Tychicus and Trophimus: Greek names, "fortunate" and "nourishing, foster child." Many manuscripts add after "accompanied by" the words "as far as Asia."
- d (20:9) Eutychus: Greek, "fortunate."

- e (20:9) Third story: Greek *tristegou*.
- f (20:15) Many later manuscripts add “at Trogyllium, and stayed there,” after “Samos.”
- g (20:21) Our Lord Jesus: many manuscripts read “our Lord Jesus Christ.”
- h (20:22) Constrained by the Spirit: or “bound in spirit.”
- i (20:24) The text of this verse varies considerably among the manuscripts. Many later ones have a longer form in which Paul says that none of these things disturbs him and that he places no value on his own life, so long as he can complete his mission with joy.
- j (20:28) Overseers: Greek *episkopous*, the word from which “bishop” derives.
- k (20:28) The church of God: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus. Many manuscripts, including Alexandrinus, Ephraemi, Codex Bezae, and the papyrus P74 (as reported), read “the church of the Lord,” and many later manuscripts conflate the two: “the church of the Lord and God.” The harder reading “of God” is generally preferred.
- l (20:28) With the blood of his own: or “with his own blood.” Westcott and Hort suggested the meaning is “with the blood of his own [Son],” taking *tou idiou* as a title; many later manuscripts read “with his own blood” in a different word order.
- m (20:32) The Lord: many manuscripts read “God.”
- n (20:35) This saying of Jesus is not recorded in the Gospels.

Chapter 21

1 When we had torn ourselves away from them and put to sea, we ran
a straight course to Cos, the next day to Rhodes, and thence to Patara.[a]
2 Finding there a ship bound across to Phoenicia, we went aboard and
set sail. 3 We sighted Cyprus, passed it on our left, and sailed on to
Syria. We landed at Tyre, where the ship was to unload its cargo. 4
We sought out the disciples and stopped there seven days. Through
the Spirit they kept telling Paul not to set foot in Jerusalem. 5 But
when our days there were ended, we left and went on our way, and
all of them, with wives and children, escorted us till we were outside
the city. Kneeling on the beach, we prayed 6 and bade one another
goodbye; then we boarded the ship, and they went back home.
7 Completing the voyage from Tyre, we arrived at Ptolemais, where
we greeted the brothers and spent a day with them. 8 Departing on
the morrow, we came to Caesarea and entered the house of Philip
the evangelist, one of the Seven, and lodged with him. 9 He had four
unmarried daughters who prophesied. 10 While we were staying on

there for a number of days, a prophet named Agabus came down from
Judea. 11 He came over to us, took up Paul's girdle, tied his own feet
and hands, and declared, "The Holy Spirit says this: 'The owner of
this girdle the Jews in Jerusalem will tie up just so, and hand over
into Gentile hands.'" 12 On hearing this, both we and the people of the
place pleaded with him not to go up to Jerusalem. 13 Then Paul replied,
"What are you about, weeping and crushing my heart? For my part,
I stand ready not only to be bound but even to die in Jerusalem for
the name of the Lord Jesus." 14 And since he would not be persuaded,
we held our peace, saying only, "The Lord's will be done."
15 After those days we packed[b] and started up to Jerusalem. 16 Certain
disciples from Caesarea traveled with us too, conducting us to one
Mnason, a Cypriot and an early disciple, at whose home we were to
be guests.[c]
17 On our reaching Jerusalem the brothers made us gladly welcome.
18 On the following day Paul went with us to James's, and the elders
all came. 19 After greeting them, he gave a detailed account, one thing
after another, of what God had done among the Gentiles through his
ministry. 20 They glorified God when they heard it, and said to him,
"You see, brother, how many tens of thousands there are among the
Jews who have believed — and every one of them a zealot for the
Law. 21 They have heard it said of you that you instruct all the Jews
living among the Gentiles to turn away from Moses, and that you tell
them to stop circumcising their children and living by our customs.
22 What, then? No doubt they will learn of your arrival.[d] 23 So do what
we tell you. We have four men who are under a vow. 24 Join these
men, undergo purification with them, and bear the cost for them to
have their heads shaved. So everybody will recognize that the reports
about you amount to nothing, and that you too keep in line, observing
the Law. 25 As regards the Gentile believers, we have written them our
decision, that they guard themselves from what is offered to idols,
from blood, from what is strangled, and from fornication."[e] 26 Then
Paul took the men, and the next day, having purified himself with
them, he went into the temple, giving notice of when the days of

purification would be completed and the offering presented for each one of them.

27 As the seven days were about to end, some Jews from the province of Asia noticed Paul in the temple. They agitated the entire crowd and seized him, 28 crying out, "Israelites, help! This is the man who goes everywhere teaching everyone to oppose our people, our Law, and this place. On top of that, he has brought Greeks into the temple and desecrated this holy place." 29 (They had seen Trophimus the Ephesian with him in the city earlier, and they assumed that Paul had taken him into the temple.) 30 The whole city was set in motion, and the people came running together. They seized Paul and dragged him out of the temple, and immediately the gates were shut. 31 As they were trying to kill him, word went up to the tribune[f] of the cohort that all Jerusalem was in confusion. 32 At once he took soldiers and centurions and ran down to them; and when they saw the tribune and the soldiers, they stopped beating Paul. 33 The commander came over, arrested him, and ordered that he be tied up with two chains. Then he asked who Paul was and what he had done. 34 In the crowd, though, some yelled this and some that; and as the din kept him from learning anything certain, he gave orders for Paul to be taken to the barracks. 35 When Paul came to the steps, he had actually to be carried by the soldiers because of the violence of the mob, 36 for the mass of the people followed, crying out, "Away with him!"

37 As Paul was about to be brought into the barracks, he said to the commander, "May I speak with you?" The commander asked, "Do you speak Greek? 38 Are you not, then, that Egyptian who lately raised an insurrection and took the four thousand Assassins[g] out to the wilderness?" 39 "I am a Jewish man," said Paul, "of Tarsus in Cilicia, citizen of a city of some note. I ask you, allow me to address the people." 40 The commander gave permission, so Paul stood on the steps and motioned to the people. When it became quiet, he spoke to them in the Hebrew language,[h] saying:

Notes

- a (21:1) Patara: Codex Bezae and some others add "and Myra."
- b (21:15) We packed: or "we made ready," possibly "we saddled horses."

- c (21:16) Codex Bezae reads, “These brought us to the village where we were to lodge with Mnason,” placing Mnason’s home on the way to Jerusalem.
- d (21:22) Many manuscripts add, “A multitude must certainly come together, for they will hear that you have come.”
- e (21:25) Codex Bezae and others add “that they should observe no such thing except to keep themselves from,” and omit “what is strangled” (compare 15:20).
- f (21:31) Tribune: Greek *chiliarchos*, “commander of a thousand,” the officer in command of the Roman cohort in the Antonia fortress.
- g (21:38) Assassins: Greek *sikariōn*, from Latin *sicarii*, “dagger men,” Jewish insurgents who stabbed their opponents in crowds. Josephus tells of an Egyptian false prophet who led a large following to the Mount of Olives about AD 54.
- h (21:40) The Hebrew language: probably Aramaic, the common language of the Jews of Palestine.

Chapter 22

1 “Brothers and fathers, hear the defense I am making to you now.”
2 And on hearing him speak to them in the Hebrew tongue, they
kept still all the more. Then he said: 3 “A Jew am I, born in Tarsus
of Cilicia, yet brought up here in this city at Gamaliel’s feet, trained
exactly in the Law of our fathers, and as full of zeal for God as all
of you are this day. 4 This Way I hounded to the death, putting men
and women alike in fetters and handing them over to prisons — 5 to
which the high priest bears me out, and all the body of elders. Letters
from them I carried to the brothers in Damascus, and I traveled there
to fetch those who were there back to Jerusalem in bonds, for their
punishment.
6 “Now it came about, as I journeyed and neared Damascus around
midday, that suddenly out of the sky a powerful light blazed all about
me. 7 I dropped to the ground and heard a voice say to me, ‘Saul, Saul,
why are you hunting me?’ 8 I answered, ‘Who are you, Lord?’ And he
said to me, ‘I am Jesus the Nazarene, the one you are hunting.’ 9 My
companions beheld the light,[a] yet they did not catch the voice of him
who was talking with me. 10 Then I said, ‘Lord, what am I to do?’ The
Lord told me, ‘Rise and continue into Damascus; there you shall be
told everything it is laid down for you to do.’ 11 And as I was sightless
because of the glory of that light, my companions took me by the
hand and so I came into Damascus.

12 “Then a certain Ananias, a man reverent according to the Law and
well attested by all the Jews dwelling there, 13 he came to me, took his
stand by my side, and told me, ‘Saul, my brother, see again!’ And in
the same hour I could see, and I looked upon him.[b] 14 And he said, ‘The
God of our fathers has chosen you beforehand to know his will, to
see the Just One, and to hear speech from his own mouth; 15 because
to all mankind you are to be his witness of the things you have seen
and heard. 16 And now, why delay? Get up and be baptized and have
your sins washed away, calling upon his name.’
17 “It happened, after my return to Jerusalem, that as I prayed in the
temple I came to be in a trance, 18 and I saw him, and he said to me,
‘Hurry, leave Jerusalem without delay; for they will not receive what
you testify concerning me.’ 19 And I said, ‘Lord, they know well enough
that from synagogue to synagogue I used to jail and whip the people
who believed on you; 20 and when the blood of your witness[c] Stephen
was poured out, I too was there, standing near, consenting to it, and
minding the clothes of his killers.’ 21 Then he told me, ‘Go; it is to the
nations far off that I shall send you.’”
22 They had given him a hearing until this word; but now they lifted
up their voices: “Rid the earth of such a man! It is not fit that he
should live!” 23 And while they bellowed and tossed their garments
about and hurled dust in the air, 24 the tribune commanded that he
be taken into the barracks, directing that he be questioned under the
lash, so he might discover the cause of their outcry against him. 25
As they tied him forward with the straps,[d] Paul said to the centurion
standing there, “Are you allowed to scourge a man who is a Roman,
and that without a verdict?” 26 Hearing this, the centurion went off
to the tribune with the report: “What are you going to do? This man
is a Roman.” 27 The tribune came up and asked him, “Say: are you a
Roman?” “I am,” said he. 28 And the tribune replied, “I paid a heavy
price for this citizenship of mine.”[e] “I, though,” said Paul, “have been
a citizen from birth.” 29 At that, the men who were to interrogate him
stepped back from him at once; and the tribune too grew fearful, once
he knew Paul was a Roman and he had put him in chains.

30 The following day, wishing to know for certain what accusation the
Jews were bringing, he loosed him and ordered the chief priests and
the whole Sanhedrin to assemble; and bringing Paul down, he stood
him before them.

Notes

- a (22:9) Beheld the light: many later manuscripts add “and were afraid.” Compare 9:7.
- b (22:13) I could see, and I looked upon him: or “I looked up at him”; the Greek *anablepsa* has both senses.
- c (22:20) Witness: Greek *martys*, the word that later came to mean “martyr.”
- d (22:25) Tied him forward with the straps: or “stretched him out for the lashes.”
- e (22:28) A heavy price: literally “a great sum of money.” Citizenship could be obtained through bribery of officials under Claudius; the tribune’s name, Claudius Lysias (23:26), suggests he took the emperor’s name on becoming a citizen.

Chapter 23

1 Fixing his gaze on the Sanhedrin, Paul said, “Brothers, with a wholly
good conscience I have conducted myself as God’s citizen until this
very day.” 2 At that, Ananias[a] the high priest directed the men standing
near him to hit him across the mouth. 3 Paul then said to him, “God
will strike you, you limewashed wall! You sit judging me by the Law,
and against the Law you bid them strike me?” 4 The bystanders said,
“Is it God’s high priest you are insulting?” 5 Paul answered, “Brothers,
I was unaware that he was high priest; for Scripture says, ‘A ruler of
your people you shall not curse.’”[b]
6 But Paul, aware that some of them were Sadducees and others Pharisees, called out in the Sanhedrin, “Brothers, a Pharisee am I, born of
Pharisees! I am being judged over our hope, the rising of the dead.”
7 No sooner had he said it than strife broke out between Pharisees
and Sadducees, and the gathering was split in two. 8 (Sadducees hold
that there is neither resurrection nor angel nor spirit, while Pharisees
confess both.) 9 A loud outcry followed; and some scribes of the
Pharisee side got up and fought it out: “Nothing evil do we find in the
man. And suppose a spirit has spoken to him, or an angel?”[c] 10 As the
strife grew great, the tribune feared they would tear Paul apart, and
he ordered the troops to come down, snatch him out of their midst,

and carry him to the barracks. 11 That next night the Lord came and
stood beside him and said, "Be of good heart; just as you bore witness
to me in Jerusalem, so in Rome too you must bear witness."
12 At daybreak the Jews formed a conspiracy and put themselves under
a curse,[d] vowing they would neither eat nor drink till Paul was dead.
13 Those who joined in this compact numbered over forty. 14 These
approached the chief priests and the elders: "Under a solemn curse
we have put ourselves to taste nothing until Paul is dead. 15 Now then,
you and the Sanhedrin must signify to the tribune that he should
bring him down before you, on the pretext of examining his affairs
more thoroughly; and before ever he gets near, we stand prepared to
do away with him." 16 But Paul's nephew, his sister's son, got wind
of the ambush; he came, went into the barracks, and reported it to
Paul. 17 Paul summoned one of the centurions and said, "Bring this
youth to the tribune; he has a report to make to him." 18 So he took
charge of him, led him before the tribune, and said, "The prisoner Paul
called me over and requested me to bring this youth to you; he has
something to tell you." 19 The tribune took his hand, drew him aside,
and asked him in private, "What is it you have to report to me?" 20 He
said, "The Jews have arranged to ask you to bring Paul down to the
Sanhedrin tomorrow, as if intending to look into his case with more
care. 21 Do not give in to them, then; for upward of forty of them lie
in wait for him, men who have cursed themselves not to eat or drink
until they have done away with him; even now they stand ready, only
awaiting your promise." 22 So the tribune sent the youth away with a
warning: "Breathe to nobody that you have made this known to me."
23 Then, calling over a pair of his centurions, he said, "By nine o'clock
tonight[e] have two hundred soldiers in readiness to march to Caesarea,
along with seventy cavalry and two hundred spearmen;[f] 24 and have
beasts on hand to mount Paul and convey him safe to Felix[g] the
governor." 25 And he wrote a letter in these terms:[h] 26 "Claudius Lysias
to the most excellent Governor Felix: greeting. 27 The Jews had laid
hold of this man and were on the point of killing him, when I inter-
vened with my troops and took him from them, having found out
that he is a Roman. 28 Wishing to ascertain the ground of their charges

against him, [I brought him down to their Sanhedrin.] 29 I discovered
that the charges concerned disputes over their Law, and that there
was nothing against him worthy of death or of bonds. 30 Information
then reached me of a plot to be carried out against the man, and I
have forthwith dispatched him to you, directing his accusers as well
to lay their case against him before you."[i]
31 So the soldiers, as ordered, took charge of Paul and conducted him
by night as far as Antipatris.[j] 32 On the morrow they went back to
the barracks, leaving the cavalry to continue with him. 33 These, on
entering Caesarea, handed the letter to the governor and presented
Paul as well before him. 34 He read it and asked from which province
Paul came; and learning it was Cilicia, 35 he said, "I will hear your case
in full whenever your accusers also are here," and he ordered him
kept under guard in Herod's praetorium.[k]

Notes

- a (23:2) Ananias: high priest about AD 47–59; the name is Hebrew Hananiah, "Yahweh has been gracious."
- b (23:5) Exod 22:28.
- c (23:9) Many later manuscripts add, "Let us not fight against God."
- d (23:12) Put themselves under a curse: Greek *anathematizō*.
- e (23:23) Nine o'clock tonight: literally "from the third hour of the night."
- f (23:23) Spearmen: the meaning of the rare Greek *dexiolabous* is uncertain; perhaps "bowmen," "slingers," or "led horses."
- g (23:24) Felix: Antonius Felix, procurator of Judea about AD 52–59; the name is Latin, "fortunate, happy."
- h (23:25) In these terms: or "of this kind." Codex Bezae and some Latin manuscripts add, "for he was afraid that the Jews might seize Paul and kill him, and that he would afterward be accused of having taken a bribe."
- i (23:30) Many later manuscripts add "Farewell."
- j (23:31) Antipatris: a town about 37 miles (60 km) northwest of Jerusalem and 25 miles (40 km) south of Caesarea.
- k (23:35) Praetorium: the governor's residence, built as a palace by Herod the Great.

Chapter 24

1 Five days afterward the high priest Ananias came down, bringing
certain elders and a pleader, one Tertullus,[a] and these laid their infor-
mation against Paul before the governor. 2 When [he] had been called
in, Tertullus opened the accusation thus: "Through you we enjoy

great peace, and by your forethought reforms are coming about for
this nation; 3 at every turn and in every place, most excellent Felix, we
welcome it with the fullest gratitude. 4 But that I may not detain you
longer, I entreat you of your forbearance to give us a brief hearing.
5 For we have found this fellow a very plague, a stirrer-up of riots
among all the Jews throughout the world, and a ringleader of the
sect of the Nazarenes.[b] 6 He even attempted to profane the temple;
and so we took hold of him.[c] 7 [d] 8 From him, should you question him
in person, you may ascertain the truth of everything of which we
charge him." 9 The Jews too joined in the attack, asserting that so these
things stood.
10 The governor then gestured for Paul to speak, and Paul answered:
"I know you have judged this nation for a good many years, and so
I am glad to defend myself before you. 11 You are able to verify that
not more than twelve days are past since I went up to worship at
Jerusalem; 12 and neither in the temple did they find me arguing with
anyone or gathering a crowd, nor in the synagogues, nor about the
city. 13 Nor can they make good to you the charges they now bring
against me. 14 This much I do confess to you: after the Way, which
they call a sect, so do I serve the God of my fathers, believing all that
accords with the Law and all that is written in the Prophets, 15 holding
a hope toward God, which these men themselves also look for, that
there is to be a resurrection of both righteous and unrighteous. 16
Therefore I too exercise myself to keep at all times a conscience void
of offense toward God and toward men. 17 Now after several years
I came to bring alms to my nation, and offerings; 18 in the midst of
which they found me purified in the temple, with no crowd and no
tumult. But some Jews from Asia — 19 these ought to be present before
you to accuse me, if they had anything against me. 20 Or else let these
men here say what wrongdoing they found when I stood before the
Sanhedrin, 21 unless it be this one cry which I uttered standing among
them: 'Over the resurrection of the dead I am under judgment before
you this day.'"
22 Felix, though, being rather well informed concerning the Way,
adjourned the hearing: "Once Lysias the tribune is down here," said

he, “I shall determine your matter.” 23 He directed the centurion to hold
him under guard, yet with a measure of freedom, forbidding none of
his friends to wait on him.
24 Some days later Felix arrived with Drusilla[e] his wife, who was a
Jewess, and he sent for Paul and listened to him on faith in Christ
Jesus. 25 But as he discoursed of righteousness and self-mastery and
the judgment to come, Felix took fright and answered, “Go your way
for the present; when I find a convenient season I will send for you.”
26 At the same time he was hoping too that money would be given
[him] by Paul; on which account he sent for him all the oftener and
conversed with him. 27 But when two years had run their course, Felix
was succeeded by Porcius Festus;[f] and wishing to do the Jews a favor,
Felix left Paul in bonds.

Notes

- a (24:1) Tertullus: a Latin name, a diminutive of Tertius, “third.” He was a professional advocate (Greek *rhētōr*, “orator”).
- b (24:5) Nazarenes: the earliest Jewish name for the followers of Jesus, after Nazareth.
- c (24:6) Took hold of him: the Westcott–Hort text ends the sentence here and continues directly with verse 8, so that “him” in verse 8 refers to Paul.
- d (24:7) The Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts do not include verse 7 (with the end of verse 6 and the beginning of verse 8); the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Some later manuscripts, and the printed editions from Erasmus, include additional words saying that the speakers would have judged him by their own Law, but that Lysias the tribune intervened, took him from their hands by force, and ordered his accusers to appear before the governor. In that reading, “him” in verse 8 refers to Lysias.
- e (24:24) Drusilla: a Latin name, a diminutive of Drusus (meaning uncertain). She was the youngest daughter of Herod Agrippa I (12:1), who had left her first husband to marry Felix. Some Western witnesses add that it was she who wished to see Paul.
- f (24:27) Festus: Porcius Festus, procurator of Judea about AD 59–62; the name is Latin, “festive, joyful.” Felix was recalled about AD 59.

Chapter 25

1 Festus, then, three days after setting foot in his province, went up
from Caesarea to Jerusalem. 2 And the chief priests and the principal
men of the Jews laid information before him against Paul, and they
kept urging him, 3 begging as a favor to themselves, to his hurt, that

he would summon him to Jerusalem — laying an ambush to make away with him on the road. 4 Festus answered, however, that Paul was being held at Caesarea, and that he himself would shortly be setting out thither. 5 "So let those among you who are men of standing," said he, "go down with me, and if there is anything amiss in the man, let them accuse him."

6 After staying among them no more than eight or ten days, he went down to Caesarea; and on the next day he took his seat on the tribunal and commanded Paul to be brought. 7 When he had come, the Jews who had come down from Jerusalem stood round him, bringing many and grave charges which they could not prove, 8 while Paul pleaded in his defense, "Neither against the Law of the Jews, nor against the temple, nor against Caesar have I committed any offense."

9 But Festus, wishing to put the Jews under obligation, answered Paul, "Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem and there be judged on these matters before me?" 10 Said Paul, "At Caesar's tribunal I stand, where I ought to be judged. To the Jews I have done no wrong, as you too know very well. 11 If I am guilty and have done anything deserving death, I do not refuse to die. But if there is no truth in the charges these men bring against me, no one has the right to hand me over to them. I appeal to Caesar!" 12 Then Festus, after conferring with his council, replied, "To Caesar you have appealed; to Caesar you shall go."

13 When some days had passed, Agrippa the king and Bernice[a] arrived at Caesarea to pay their respects to Festus. 14 As they were staying there a good many days, Festus laid Paul's case before the king, saying, "There is a man left a prisoner by Felix, 15 about whom, when I was at Jerusalem, the chief priests and elders of the Jews brought information, asking for sentence against him. 16 I told them that Romans have no custom of handing over anyone as a favor, before the accused has faced the accusers in person and had a chance to answer the charges. 17 When therefore they had assembled here, I lost no time; the day following I sat down upon the judgment seat and gave orders for the man to be fetched. 18 When the accusers stood up around him, they brought no charge of such evil deeds as I was supposing; 19 rather

they had certain questions against him about their own religion[b] and about one Jesus, who was dead, whom Paul affirmed to be alive. 20 Being at a loss how to inquire into these things, I asked whether he would go to Jerusalem and be judged there concerning them. 21 But when Paul appealed to be kept for the decision of His Majesty the Emperor,[c] I ordered him held until I could send him on to Caesar." 22 Agrippa said to Festus, "I would like to hear this man myself." Festus replied, "Tomorrow you will hear him."

23 Accordingly, on the morrow, there came Agrippa and Bernice amid much display, and they went into the hall of hearing with the tribunes and the city's leading men; and Festus gave the word, and Paul was led in. 24 And Festus said, "King Agrippa, and all you men here present with us, you behold this man concerning whom the whole multitude of the Jews petitioned me, both in Jerusalem and here, crying out that he ought not to live any longer. 25 But I found that he had done nothing deserving of death; and as he himself appealed to His Majesty, I determined to send him. 26 Yet I have nothing definite to write to my lord[d] about him. Therefore I have brought him out before you all, and especially before you, King Agrippa, so that after the examination has been held I may have something to write. 27 For it seems to me unreasonable, in sending a prisoner, not to signify as well the charges against him."

Notes

- a (25:13) Agrippa and Bernice: Herod Agrippa II, son of Agrippa I (12:1), king of territories north and east of Galilee; the name is Latin, of uncertain meaning. Bernice, his sister, is the Macedonian form of Greek Pherenike, "bringer of victory."
- b (25:19) Religion: or "superstition" (Greek *deisidaimonia*); compare 17:22.
- c (25:21) His Majesty the Emperor: Greek *ho Sebastos*, "the Revered One," the Greek equivalent of the title Augustus; here Nero.
- d (25:26) My lord: Greek *kyrios*, used of the emperor.

Chapter 26

1 Agrippa said to Paul, "Leave is given you to speak on your own behalf." Then Paul stretched forth his hand and made his defense: 2 "Touching all the things whereof I am accused by Jews, King Agrippa, I count myself fortunate that it is before you I am to answer for myself

today, [3] the more so because you are expert in all the customs and controversies among Jews. I pray you, therefore, hear me out with patience.

[4] "My manner of life from youth, spent from the beginning among my own nation and at Jerusalem, all Jews know, [5] having known me a long while, if only they would bear witness, that after the strictest party of our religion I lived a Pharisee. [6] And now for the hope of the promise made by God to our fathers I stand here on trial, [7] a promise our twelve tribes, earnestly serving night and day, hope to attain. For this hope, O king, I am accused by Jews! [8] Why is it judged a thing past belief among you, if God raises the dead?

[9] "I myself, indeed, once thought it my duty to do many things in opposition to the name of Jesus of Nazareth. [10] And this I did in Jerusalem: many of the saints I shut up in prisons, having received authority from the chief priests, and when they were put to death I cast my vote[a] against them. [11] In all the synagogues I often had them punished and tried to make them blaspheme. I was so furiously angry at them that I even chased them to cities in foreign lands.

[12] "On such an errand I was journeying to Damascus with authority and commission from the chief priests, [13] when at midday, O king, I saw on the road a light out of heaven, brighter than the brilliance of the sun, shining round about me and those who journeyed with me. [14] And when we had all fallen to the earth, I heard a voice saying to me in the Hebrew language,[b] 'Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me? It is hard for you to kick against the goads.'[c] [15] I asked, 'Lord, who are you?' The Lord replied, 'Jesus am I, whom you persecute. [16] But rise and stand upon your feet; for to this end have I appeared to you, to appoint you a servant and a witness both of the things in which you have seen me[d] and of those in which I will appear to you, [17] rescuing you from the people and from the Gentiles, to whom I send you, [18] I am sending you to open their eyes, so that they will turn from the dark to the light, and from Satan's control to God. Then they will receive forgiveness of sins and a share with those who have been made holy by trusting in me.'

19 Hence, King Agrippa, to that vision from heaven I was not disobedient, 20 but to them of Damascus first, and at Jerusalem, and over all
the region of Judea, and to the Gentiles, I proclaimed that they must
repent and turn to God, performing deeds worthy of repentance. 21 On
this account Jews seized me in the temple and tried to make an end
of me. 22 Having therefore obtained the help that is from God, I stand
to this day bearing witness to small and great alike, saying nothing
beyond what the prophets and Moses said should come to pass: 23 that
the Messiah was to suffer, and that he, first of the resurrection from
the dead, would proclaim light both to the people and to the Gentiles."
24 And as he was so making his defense, Festus said with a loud voice,
"You are mad, Paul! Your great learning is turning you to madness." 25
But Paul said, "I am not mad, most excellent Festus, but am uttering
words of truth and soberness. 26 For the king knows of these matters,
and to him I speak with boldness; for I am persuaded that none of
these things escapes his notice, since this was not done in a corner. 27
King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know that you believe."
28 And Agrippa said to Paul, "In a little you would persuade me to play
the Christian!"[e] 29 And Paul said, "I would pray to God that, whether
in little or in much, not only you but also all who hear me this day
might become such as I am — save for these chains."
30 Then the king rose, and the governor and Bernice, and those who
sat with them; 31 and when they had withdrawn, they spoke to one
another, saying, "This man does nothing deserving death or imprisonment." 32 And Agrippa said to Festus, "This man could have been
set at liberty, had he not appealed to Caesar."

Notes

- a (26:10) Cast my vote: literally "brought down a pebble," the voting stone; whether Paul had a formal vote in the Sanhedrin is uncertain, and the phrase may simply mean "I gave my approval."
- b (26:14) The Hebrew language: probably Aramaic.
- c (26:14) Kick against the goads: a Greek proverb for useless resistance, from an ox kicking against the pointed stick of its driver.
- d (26:16) Seen me: some manuscripts read "have seen."
- e (26:28) In a little you would persuade me to play the Christian: the Greek is difficult. It may mean "In a short time," or "With so little," and the verb may mean

"persuade me to become" or "persuade me to act as." Many later manuscripts read "You almost persuade me to become a Christian."

Chapter 27

1 Now when it was resolved that we should sail away for Italy, they
handed over Paul and certain other prisoners to a centurion named
Julius,[a] of the Augustan Cohort.[b] 2 Embarking in a ship of Adramyt-
tium,[c] which was about to sail to the ports along the coast of Asia, we
put to sea, there being with us Aristarchus, a Macedonian of Thessa-
lonica. 3 The next day we landed at Sidon. Julius treated Paul with
kindness and allowed him to visit his friends so they could provide
for his needs. 4 Putting out from thence, we sailed under the lee of
Cyprus, because the winds were against us. 5 And when we had sailed
across the open sea off Cilicia and Pamphylia, we came down to Myra
in Lycia.[d] 6 There the centurion found a ship of Alexandria sailing for
Italy, and put us aboard her. 7 Many a day we crept along slowly and
with much ado got abreast of Cnidus; then, the wind forbidding our
approach, we slipped under the lee of Crete by Salmone. 8 Coasting
along it with difficulty, we came to a certain place called Fair Havens,
near which was the town of Lasea.

9 Much time having now been spent, and the voyage being already
perilous because even the Fast[e] was already gone by, Paul gave them
warning, 10 saying to them, "Sirs, I perceive that this voyage will be
with injury and heavy loss, not only of the cargo and the ship but also
of our lives." 11 But the centurion paid more heed to the pilot and to the
owner of the ship than to the things spoken by Paul. 12 And because
the harbor was ill suited to winter in, the majority advised putting
out from there, in hope that they might somehow reach Phoenix, a
harbor of Crete looking toward the southwest and northwest,[f] and
winter there.

13 When a south wind blew softly, supposing they had gained their
purpose, they weighed anchor and sailed along Crete, hugging the
shore. 14 But not long after, there rushed down from it a tempestuous
wind, the one called Euraquilo.[g] 15 And when the ship was caught and
could not face the wind, we gave way to it and were driven along. 16

Darting in to the shelter of a small island named Cauda,[h] we barely
managed to secure the skiff. 17 After hoisting it up, they used helps,
undergirding the ship; and fearing lest they should run aground
on the Syrtis,[i] they lowered the gear,[j] and so were driven along. 18
As we were exceedingly storm-tossed, the next day they began to
throw cargo overboard; 19 and the third day they flung out the ship's
furniture with their own hands. 20 And when neither sun nor stars
appeared for many days, and no small tempest lay upon us, all hope
of our being saved was at last being taken away.
21 When they had long gone without food, Paul stood up in their midst
and said, "Sirs, you ought to have hearkened to me and not have set
sail from Crete, and so have been spared this injury and loss. 22 Yet
now I counsel you to take heart; for there shall be no loss of life
among you, but only of the ship. 23 For there stood by me this night
an angel of the God whose I am and whom I serve, 24 and he told me,
'Paul, have no fear. You are going to stand before Caesar. And God
has granted you the lives of all who are sailing with you.' 25 So take
heart, sirs; for I have faith in God that it shall be even as I have been
told. 26 But we must run aground on a certain island."
27 On the fourteenth night, as we were drifting across the Adriatic Sea,[k]
around midnight the sailors sensed that land was near. 28 And taking
soundings they found a hundred and twenty feet; a little farther on
they sounded again and found ninety feet.[l] 29 And fearing lest we
should be cast upon rocky places, they let go four anchors from the
stern and longed for day to come. 30 And as the sailors were seeking
to flee from the ship and had lowered the boat into the sea under
color of laying out anchors from the bow, 31 Paul said to the centurion
and the soldiers, "Unless these men abide in the ship, you cannot be
saved." 32 Then the soldiers cut away the ropes of the boat and let her
fall off.
33 While day was coming on, Paul besought them all to partake of food,
saying, "This is the fourteenth day you have continued in suspense
and without food, having taken nothing. 34 Therefore I urge you to
take some food, for it is for your preservation; for not a hair shall
perish from the head of any of you." 35 And having said this, he took

bread, gave thanks to God in the presence of all, and broke it and began to eat. 36 Then they were all encouraged and themselves also took food. 37 (We were in all about seventy-six persons[m] in the ship.) 38 And when they had eaten enough, they lightened the ship, casting out the wheat into the sea.

39 When daylight came, they did not recognize the coast, but they saw a bay with a sandy beach, and they decided to try to run the ship aground there. 40 So casting off the anchors, they left them in the sea, at the same time loosing the lashings of the steering oars; and hoisting the foresail to the wind, they made for the beach. 41 But striking a place where two seas met,[n] they beached the vessel; the prow stuck and stayed fast, unmoved, while the stern began to go to pieces under the violence of the surf. 42 The soldiers' counsel was to kill the prisoners, lest any should swim off and escape. 43 But the centurion, wishing to bring Paul safely through, kept them from their purpose, and ordered that those who could swim should cast themselves overboard first and get to land, 44 and the rest, some on planks and some on pieces of the ship. And so it came to pass that all were brought safe to land.

Notes

- a (27:1) Julius: a Roman family name, perhaps from Iulus, legendary son of Aeneas; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (27:1) Augustan Cohort: or "Imperial Cohort."
- c (27:2) Adramyttium: a port in Mysia, on the northwest coast of Asia Minor.
- d (27:5) Myra in Lycia: some Western witnesses add that the crossing took fifteen days.
- e (27:9) The Fast: the Day of Atonement, on the tenth of Tishri, in late September or early October, after which sailing on the Mediterranean was considered dangerous.
- f (27:12) Southwest and northwest: literally "toward Lips and toward Chorus," the names of the southwest and northwest winds; the exact sense is uncertain.
- g (27:14) Euraquilo: a hybrid of Greek *euros*, "east wind," and Latin *aquilo*, "north wind": a northeaster. Many later manuscripts read *Euroclydōn*.
- h (27:16) Cauda: many manuscripts read "Clauda." The island is modern Gavdos, south of Crete.
- i (27:17) Syrtis: the gulf of shoals and quicksands off the coast of Libya.
- j (27:17) Lowered the gear: perhaps "let down the sea anchor" or "lowered the mainsail"; the Greek is uncertain.
- k (27:27) Adriatic Sea: in ancient usage the central Mediterranean between Greece, Italy, and Africa, not only the modern Adriatic.

- l (27:28) A hundred and twenty feet ... ninety feet: literally “twenty fathoms ... fifteen fathoms”; about 37 and 27 meters.
- m (27:37) Seventy-six persons: so Codex Vaticanus, followed by the Westcott–Hort text. Most manuscripts read “two hundred seventy-six,” and some “two hundred seventy-five.” In Greek numerals the difference may arise from a single letter.
- n (27:41) A place where two seas met: or “a sandbar,” “a reef.”

Chapter 28

1 Once safe ashore, we learned then that the island was called Malta.[a]
2 The islanders[b] showed us unusual kindness. Because it had begun
to rain and was cold, they built a fire and welcomed all of us. 3 But
when Paul had gathered a bundle of sticks and laid them on the fire,
a viper came out by reason of the heat and fastened on his hand. 4
When the natives saw the creature hanging from his hand, they said
one to another, “No doubt this man is a murderer, whom, though he
has escaped the sea, Justice[c] has not suffered to live.” 5 But he flung the
beast off into the flames and took no hurt. 6 But they were expecting
him to swell up or suddenly fall down dead; and after they had waited
a long while and saw nothing amiss come to him, they changed their
minds and said that he was a god.
7 Now in the neighborhood of that place were lands belonging to the
chief man of the island, named Publius,[d] who received us and enter-
tained us courteously three days. 8 And it fell out that the father of
Publius lay sick of fever and dysentery; to whom Paul went in, and
having prayed and laid his hands on him, he healed him. 9 When this
had taken place, the rest [also] on the island who had diseases came
and were cured. 10 They also honored us with many honors, and when
we were setting sail they put on board such things as we needed.
11 After three months we sailed in a ship from Alexandria that had
spent the winter at the island. It carried the Twin Brothers[e] as its
figurehead. 12 Putting in at Syracuse, we stayed there three days. 13 And
thence we made a circuit[f] and arrived at Rhegium; and after one day
a south wind sprang up, and on the second day we came to Puteoli. 14
There we found brothers and were entreated to stay with them seven
days. And so we came to Rome. 15 The brothers there, having had word
of us, came out from the city to meet us at Appius’ Market and the

Three Inns;[g] and at the sight of them Paul gave God thanks and was heartened.
16 On our entry into Rome,[h] leave was granted Paul to lodge on his own, along with the soldier set to guard him.
17 It came to pass after three days that he called together the leading men of the Jews; and when they had come together, he said to them, “Brothers, though I had done nothing against the people or the customs of our fathers, yet I was delivered a prisoner from Jerusalem into the hands of the Romans, 18 who, when they had examined me, were minded to release me, because there was no cause for death in me. 19 But when the Jews objected, I had no choice but to appeal to Caesar, even though I had nothing to accuse my own nation of. 20 On this account, then, I invited you here, to see you face to face and talk with you; for it is for Israel’s hope that I wear this chain.” 21 They told him, “For our part, no letters about you have reached us out of Judea, nor has any brother arrived to report or tell anything evil about you. 22 But we think it fitting to hear from you what your views are; for as concerning this sect, it is known to us that everywhere it is spoken against.”
23 And when they had appointed him a day, they came to him at his lodging in greater numbers. To them he expounded the matter from morning till evening, testifying to the kingdom of God and seeking to persuade them concerning Jesus from both the Law of Moses and the Prophets.
24 And some were persuaded by what was spoken, while others disbelieved.
25 And being at variance among themselves, they departed, after Paul had spoken one word: “Well did the Holy Spirit speak through Isaiah the prophet to your fathers,
26 saying,

‘Go to this people, and say,
By hearing you will hear, and shall in no wise understand;
and seeing you will see, and shall in no wise perceive.
27 For the heart of this people has grown gross,
and with their ears they have heard heavily,

and their eyes they have closed;
lest at any time they should see with their eyes,
and hear with their ears,
and understand with their heart,
and turn again, and I should heal them.'[i]
28 Know, then, that to the Gentiles this saving work of God is sent; and
they, for their part, will listen."
29 [j]
30 And he abode two whole years in his own hired dwelling,[k] and
welcomed all who came in to him, 31 proclaiming the kingdom of God
and teaching the things concerning the Lord Jesus Christ with all
boldness, unhindered.

Notes

- a (28:1) Malta: Greek *Melitē*; the Westcott–Hort text, following Codex Vaticanus, reads *Melitēnē*. The name is perhaps from Phoenician, "refuge," but the meaning is uncertain.
- b (28:2) Natives: Greek *barbaroi*, people who did not speak Greek; the Maltese spoke a Punic dialect.
- c (28:4) Justice: Greek *Dikē*, the goddess of justice and retribution.
- d (28:7) Publius: a Latin first name, perhaps related to *populus*, "people"; the meaning is uncertain. His title, "chief man" (Greek *prōtos*), is attested on Maltese inscriptions.
- e (28:11) The Twin Brothers: Greek *Dioskouroi*, Castor and Pollux, sons of Zeus and patrons of sailors.
- f (28:13) Made a circuit: some manuscripts read "cast off."
- g (28:15) Appius' Market and the Three Inns: Latin Forum Appii and Tres Tabernae, stations on the Appian Way, about 43 and 33 miles (69 and 53 km) south of Rome.
- h (28:16) Entry into Rome: many manuscripts, mainly Western and Byzantine, add "the centurion delivered the prisoners to the commander of the camp," and continue "but Paul was allowed to live by himself outside the camp."
- i (28:27) Isa 6:9–10, following the Greek translation of the Old Testament.
- j (28:29) The Westcott–Hort text and the earliest manuscripts do not include verse 29; the number is kept here only to preserve the traditional verse numbering. Some later manuscripts add a sentence saying that after Paul spoke, the Jews left, arguing vigorously among themselves.
- k (28:30) Hired dwelling: or "at his own expense."

Romans

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul,[a] slave[b] of Christ Jesus,[c] an apostle by calling, set apart
for God's gospel[d] 2 the gospel God promised beforehand through his
prophets in holy writings, 3 concerning his Son, who as to the flesh
was born from the seed of David, 4 and who was installed as Son of
God with power, by the Spirit of holiness,[e] when he rose from the
dead: Jesus Christ our Lord. 5 Through him we were given grace and
a commission as apostle, to bring about faithful obedience[f] among
every non-Jewish nation for the sake of his name; 6 and among them
are you also, called to belong to Jesus Christ. 7 To all who are in Rome,[g]
beloved of God, called to be saints:[h] grace to you and peace from God
our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.
8 First, I thank my God through Jesus Christ for all of you, because
the report of your faith is spreading through the whole world. 9 For
God, whom I serve in my spirit in the gospel of his Son, is my witness
how without ceasing I make mention of you, 10 always asking in my
prayers that somehow, at last, by God's will I may succeed in coming
to you. 11 For I long to see you, to share with you some spiritual gift so
that you may be made firm; 12 or rather, that we may be encouraged
together among you, each by the other's faith, both yours and mine.
13 Brothers,[i] I want you to know that many a time I have planned
to come to you, though up to now I have been hindered, in order
to gather some fruit among you as well, just as among the other
Gentiles. 14 To Greeks and to barbarians,[j] to the wise and to the foolish,
I am a debtor; 15 so, for my part, I am eager to preach the gospel to
you also who are in Rome.
16 I am not ashamed of the gospel,[k] for it is the power of God bringing
salvation to all who believe, the Jew first[l] and the Greek as well. 17 For

God's righteousness[m] is unveiled in it, starting from faith and aiming at faith; as scripture says, "The righteous person will live by faith."[n]
18 For God's wrath is being revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and wickedness of people who by their wickedness hold down the truth. 19 because what may be known of God lies open before them; God himself has shown it to them. 20 From the world's creation onward, the unseen things of God, his everlasting power and godhead, are discerned and grasped through what he has made, leaving them without defense. 21 For although they knew God, they did not glorify him as God or give thanks, but became futile in their reasonings, and their senseless heart was darkened. 22 Claiming to be wise, they became fools, 23 and exchanged the glory of the immortal God for a likeness in the shape of mortal man and of birds and four-footed beasts and creeping things.
24 That is why God handed them over, in their hearts' desires, to uncleanness, so that their bodies were degraded among them. 25 They traded God's truth for a falsehood, and revered and served what was made instead of the Maker, who is praised forever. Amen.
26 For this reason God gave them up to dishonorable passions. Their females exchanged natural relations for those contrary to nature; 27 and in the same way the men abandoned natural intimacy with women and burned with desire for one another, men doing shameful things with men and receiving in themselves the fitting penalty for their straying.
28 And since they did not see fit to keep God in their knowledge, God gave them up to an unfit mind,[o] to do what ought not to be done. 29 They have been filled with every kind of wickedness, evil, greed, malice; they are full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, spite. They are gossips, 30 gossips, God-haters,[p] bullies, haughty, braggarts, devisers of wrongdoing, defiant toward parents, 31 senseless, faithless,[q] heartless, ruthless.[r] 32 They know well God's decree that people who do such things are worthy of death; yet they do them, and what is more, they approve of others who do them.

Notes

- a (1:1) Paul: Latin *Paulus*, "small"; his Jewish name was Saul (Acts 13:9).

- b (1:1) Slave: Greek *doulos*, a slave or bondservant; also used of God's servants such as Moses and the prophets.
- c (1:1) Christ Jesus: *Christ* (Greek *Christos*) means "Anointed One," the equivalent of Hebrew *Mashiach*, "Messiah." In Paul's letters it usually functions as part of Jesus' name. Some manuscripts read "Jesus Christ."
- d (1:1) Gospel: Greek *euangelion*, "good news."
- e (1:4) Spirit of holiness: probably the Holy Spirit, though some understand Jesus' own holy spirit.
- f (1:5) The obedience of faith: either "the obedience that consists in faith" or "the obedience that comes from faith."
- g (1:7) In Rome: a few witnesses, including Codex Boernerianus (G) and some early writers (as reported), lack "in Rome" here and in 1:15, perhaps because the letter circulated more generally.
- h (1:7) Saints: Greek *hagioi*, "holy ones," those set apart for God; Paul's usual term for believers.
- i (1:13) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, used by Paul of fellow believers, women and men alike.
- j (1:14) Barbarians: non-Greek-speaking peoples.
- k (1:16) The gospel: many later manuscripts read "the gospel of Christ."
- l (1:16) First: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; Vaticanus and Codex Boernerianus (as reported) lack it.
- m (1:17) The righteousness of God: either God's own righteousness (his saving justice and faithfulness) or the righteous standing that God gives.
- n (1:17) Hab 2:4. Or "The righteous will live by faith." The Hebrew text reads "by his faithfulness."
- o (1:28) An unfit mind: Greek *adokimon noun*, a wordplay with *edokimasan*, "they did not see fit."
- p (1:30) Haters of God: or "hateful to God."
- q (1:31) Faithless: or "covenant-breakers," "untrustworthy."
- r (1:31) Ruthless: many later manuscripts add "implacable."

Chapter 2

[1] So you have no defense, whoever you are, O man, who sit in judgment. In judging the other person you pass sentence on yourself, since you who judge are doing those same things. [2] We know that the judgment of God falls in accordance with truth on those who practice such things. [3] O man, judging people who do such things while doing them yourself, do you really think you will escape God's judgment? [4] Or do you think lightly of his rich goodness, his patience and long-suffering, unaware that the goodness of God is leading you toward

repentance? 5 With your hard and unrepentant heart you are heaping
up wrath against yourself for the day of wrath, the day God's just
judgment is unveiled. 6 He "will give back to every person as his deeds
deserve":[a] 7 to those who by perseverance in good work seek glory
and honor and immortality, eternal life; 8 but to those who are self-
seeking[b] and disobey the truth but obey wickedness, wrath and fury.
9 Trouble and anguish will come upon every human soul that works
evil, upon the Jew first and the Greek as well; 10 but glory, honor and
peace upon everyone who works what is good, upon the Jew first and
the Greek as well. 11 For God shows no partiality.
12 All who have sinned without the law will also perish without the
law, and all who have sinned under the law will be judged by the law.
13 For it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous before God,
but the doers of the law who will be justified. 14 Whenever Gentiles,
who lack the law, do by nature what the law contains, these people,
though they lack the law, are their own law. 15 They display the law's
work inscribed on their hearts; their conscience adds its testimony,
and their thoughts in turn accuse them or perhaps defend them, 16
on the day when God, as my gospel declares, judges people's hidden
things through Christ Jesus.[c]
17 Now you bear the name of Jew; you lean on the law; you make your
boast in God; 18 you know his will and can tell what really matters,[d]
being taught out of the law; 19 and if you are confident that you are a
guide to the blind, a light to those in darkness, 20 an instructor of the
foolish, a teacher of infants, possessing in the law the very shape of
knowledge and truth. 21 Well then, you who teach another, will you
not teach yourself? You who proclaim, "Do not steal," are you a thief?
22 You who forbid adultery, do you commit it yourself? You who detest
idols, do you plunder their temples?[e] 23 You who boast in the law, do
you dishonor God by breaking the law? 24 For, as it is written, "The
name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you."[f]
25 Circumcision does have worth if you keep the law; but if you break
the law, your circumcision turns into uncircumcision. 26 If, then, an
uncircumcised man observes the law's just demands, will his lack
of circumcision not be reckoned to him as circumcision? 27 Then the

one who is physically uncircumcised but fulfills the law will judge you, who with the written code and circumcision are a breaker of the law. 28 For a Jew is not one outwardly, nor is circumcision something outward in the flesh. 29 No, the true Jew is one in secret, and true circumcision is of the heart, in the Spirit, not in the letter. Such a person's praise[g] comes from God, not from people.

Notes

- a (2:6) Ps 62:12; Prov 24:12.
- b (2:8) Self-seeking: Greek *eritheia*, selfish ambition or rivalry.
- c (2:16) Christ Jesus: some manuscripts read "Jesus Christ." Verses 14–15 may be a parenthesis, with v. 16 continuing v. 13.
- d (2:18) Tell what really matters: or "approve what is excellent."
- e (2:22) Rob temples: perhaps plundering pagan temples, or more broadly committing sacrilege.
- f (2:24) Isa 52:5, following the Greek Old Testament; compare Ezek 36:20.
- g (2:29) Praise: a wordplay on *Jew* (from *Judah*), which means "praised" (Gen 29:35; 49:8).

Chapter 3

1 What advantage, then, does the Jew have? Or what good is there in circumcision? 2 Much, in every respect. To begin with, it was to them that God's oracles were committed. 3 What then if some proved unfaithful? Will their faithlessness cancel out God's faithfulness? 4 Far from it! Let God be found true, though every human being be a liar, as it stands written, "So that you may be shown in the right in your words, and win when you are put on trial."[a] 5 But if our wrongdoing brings out God's righteousness, what are we to say? That God does wrong in bringing his wrath upon us? (I am speaking in human terms.) 6 Far from it! For then how could God judge the world? 7 Yet if my lie makes God's truth overflow all the more to his glory, why should I, of all people, still be judged a sinner? 8 And why not say, as we are slanderously charged with saying, and as some assert that we say, "Let us do evil so that good may come"? Their condemnation is deserved.

9 What follows? Do we have the upper hand?[b] By no means. We have already brought the charge that Jews and Greeks alike all lie under sin, 10 as it is written: "There is no one righteous, not even one; 11 there

is no one who understands; there is no one who seeks out God. 12
Every one has swerved away; all alike have gone bad. Not one does
what is kind, no, not a single one.[c] 13 Their throat is a grave thrown
open; with their tongues they keep deceiving.[d] The venom of asps
is under their lips.[e] 14 Their mouth is full of cursing and bitterness.[f]
15 Swift are their feet to shed blood; 16 ruin and misery lie along their
paths, 17 and the way of peace they have not known.[g] 18 There is no
fear of God before their eyes."[h]
19 Now we understand that everything the law declares is addressed
to those under the law, so that no one has anything to say and the
entire world is held accountable to God. 20 For by works of the law
no flesh will be justified[i] before him;[j] for through the law comes the
knowledge of sin.
21 But now, apart from the law, God's righteousness has been
disclosed, attested by the Law and the Prophets: 22 a righteousness of
God that comes through faith in Jesus Christ[k] to all who believe. No
distinction is made, 23 all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,
24 and are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is
in Christ Jesus. 25 He is the one God set forth publicly as a mercy seat,[l]
through faith, by means of his blood, to show forth his righteousness,
since in his patience God had let earlier sins go unpunished; 26 it was
to demonstrate his righteousness at the present time, so that he might
be righteous and also the one who justifies the person who has faith
in Jesus.
27 Where, then, is boasting? It has been shut out. By what kind of law?
A law of works? No, but by a law of faith. 28 For we reckon that a
person is justified by faith apart from works of the law. 29 Or is God the
God of Jews only? Is he not the God of Gentiles also? Yes, of Gentiles
also, 30 if indeed God is one;[m] he will declare the circumcised righteous
out of faith, and the uncircumcised by means of the very same faith.
31 Do we then nullify the law through faith? Far from it! Instead, we
uphold the law.

Notes

- a (3:4) Ps 51:4 (50:6 Greek), following the Greek Old Testament.

- b (3:9) Do we have the upper hand?: the meaning of Greek *proechometha* is disputed; it may mean “Are we at a disadvantage?” or “Are we making excuses?”
- c (3:12) Ps 14:1–3 (13:1–3 Greek); 53:1–3; compare Eccl 7:20.
- d (3:13) Ps 5:9.
- e (3:13) Ps 140:3.
- f (3:14) Ps 10:7.
- g (3:17) Isa 59:7–8; compare Prov 1:16.
- h (3:18) Ps 36:1.
- i (3:20) Justified: Greek *dikaioō*, “declare righteous, acquit, put in the right”; related to *dikaiosynē*, “righteousness,” and *dikaios*, “righteous.”
- j (3:20) Compare Ps 143:2.
- k (3:22) Faith in Jesus Christ: or “the faithfulness of Jesus Christ.” The Greek genitive can be read either way; the same question arises in 3:26 and Gal 2:16, 20; 3:22; Phil 3:9. “Jesus” is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text and absent from Vaticanus (as reported).
- l (3:25) Mercy seat: Greek *hilastērion*, the word used in the Greek Old Testament for the gold cover of the ark of the covenant, where atoning blood was sprinkled on the Day of Atonement (Lev 16:14–15); or more generally “a means of atonement,” “a sacrifice of atonement,” “propitiation.”
- m (3:30) God is one: echoing the Shema (Deut 6:4).

Chapter 4

1 What then shall we say of Abraham,[a] our forefather according to the
flesh?[b] 2 For if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to
boast about, but not before God. 3 For what does the Scripture say?
“Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness.”[c]
4 Now to the one who works, his wages are not credited as a gift but
as what is owed. 5 But to the one who does not work, yet trusts in
him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is credited as righteousness. 6
Just so David also speaks of the blessedness of the man to whom God
credits righteousness apart from works: 7 “How happy are they whose
lawbreaking is pardoned, whose sins are hidden from view! 8 How
happy the man against whom the Lord will by no means reckon sin!”[d]
9 This blessedness, then: does it come upon the circumcised, or upon
the uncircumcised too? For we say, “Faith was credited to Abraham
as righteousness.” 10 Under what circumstances, then, was it credited?
Was he circumcised at the time, or not? He was not yet circumcised;
he was uncircumcised. 11 And he was given circumcision as a sign, a

seal of the righteousness by faith that was his in uncircumcision. So he is father to all who believe while uncircumcised, so that righteousness is credited to them as well, 12 and the father of the circumcised, to those who are not only circumcised but who also walk in the footsteps of the faith our father Abraham had while uncircumcised.
13 For the promise to Abraham and his offspring, that he would inherit the world, did not arrive by way of the law but by the righteousness that comes from faith. 14 For if it is the adherents of the law who are heirs, faith has been emptied of meaning and the promise made void.
15 For the law produces wrath; but where no law exists, there is no violation either. 16 For this reason it comes from faith, in order to be by grace, so that the promise stands firm for every descendant, not only the one belonging to the law, but also the one belonging to Abraham's faith. He is father of us all, 17 just as Scripture says, "I have appointed you father of many nations."[e] He stands so before God, in whom he put his faith, the God who makes the dead alive and summons what does not exist as though it did. 18 Past all hope, he believed in hope, that he would be made father of many nations, in keeping with the word, "So shall your descendants be."[f] 19 Without wavering in faith he took full account of[g] his body, already[h] as good as dead at about a hundred years of age, and of the deadness of Sarah's[i] womb. 20 He did not waver in distrust at God's promise; instead he grew strong in faith and gave glory to God, 21 being fully assured that what God had promised he could also perform. 22 So it was that "it was credited to him as righteousness." 23 But the phrase "it was credited to him" was not recorded for his benefit alone, 24 but for ours also. It will be credited to us who believe in him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead, 25 who was handed over for our trespasses and raised for our justification.

Notes

- a (4:1) What then shall we say of Abraham: so the Westcott–Hort text with Vaticanus (as reported). Most manuscripts include the verb "found," giving a question like "What, then, are we to say that Abraham, our forefather, discovered by natural means?" (with differences in word order). *Abraham* is explained in Gen 17:5 as "father of a multitude."
- b (4:1) According to the flesh: that is, by physical descent.

- c (4:3) Gen 15:6.
- d (4:8) Ps 32:1–2 (31:1–2 Greek). In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.
- e (4:17) Gen 17:5.
- f (4:18) Gen 15:5.
- g (4:19) Took full account of: so the Westcott–Hort text with the earliest manuscripts; most later manuscripts insert “not,” giving “Not being weak in faith, he did not consider his own body.”
- h (4:19) Already: Greek *ēdē*, bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text and lacking in some manuscripts.
- i (4:19) Sarah: Hebrew, “princess” (Gen 17:15).

Chapter 5

1 Having been justified, then, by faith, let us have[a] peace toward God
through our Lord Jesus Christ. 2 Through him we have also been
granted entry by faith[b] into this grace where we now stand, and we
boast in our hope of sharing God’s glory. 3 More than that, we exult
even in our afflictions, knowing that affliction works out endurance, 4
and endurance, tested character, and tested character, hope; 5 and this
hope does not disappoint, since God’s love has flooded our hearts by
the Holy Spirit he has given us.
6 For while we were still helpless, at the appointed time Christ died
on behalf of the ungodly. 7 It is rare for anyone to die for a just
person, though for a truly good person someone might possibly find
the courage to die. 8 But God proves how he loves us: Christ died for
us when we were yet sinners. 9 How much more, then, now that we
have been justified by his blood, shall we be saved through him from
the wrath. 10 For if we were reconciled to God through his Son’s death
while still enemies, how much more certain is it that, now reconciled,
we will be saved through his life. 11 And not only that, but we also
exult in God through our Lord Jesus Christ,[c] through whom we have
now received the reconciliation.
12 Therefore, just as through one man sin made its entrance into the
world, and through sin death, so death spread to all people, inasmuch
as all sinned.[d] 13 Sin was already present in the world until the law
came, though no account of sin is kept where law is absent. 14 Still,
death reigned from Adam[e] until Moses, even over people whose sins

were not like Adam's offense; Adam is a pattern of the one who was coming.
15 But the gift does not match the offense. For if the many died through one person's offense, how much more has God's grace, and the gift that came by the grace of one person, Jesus Christ, overflowed to the many. 16 Again, the gift does not resemble the outcome of the one man's sin. For judgment followed one trespass and led to condemnation, but the free gift followed many trespasses and led to acquittal. 17 For if, by the trespass of the one, death reigned through that one, much more will those who receive the abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one, Jesus Christ.
18 So then, as one trespass led to condemnation for all people, so too one righteous act[f] leads to acquittal and life for all people. 19 For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one the many will be made righteous. 20 The law slipped in so that the offense would multiply; but where sin multiplied, grace multiplied far more, 21 so that, as sin reigned in death, so also grace might reign through righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

Notes

- a (5:1) Let us have: Greek *echōmen*, the reading of the Westcott–Hort text, supported by many early witnesses, including Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (original hands), Alexandrinus, Ephraemi, and Bezae (as reported). Other witnesses, including correctors of Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, read *echomen*, "we have," printed in NA28 and SBLGNT. The two forms were pronounced alike in later Greek, and many scholars judge "we have" to suit the context of vv. 1–11 better.
- b (5:2) By faith: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; lacking in Vaticanus, Bezae, and some others (as reported).
- c (5:11) Jesus Christ: "Christ" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- d (5:12) Inasmuch as all sinned: or "because all sinned"; Greek *eph' hō*. The Latin rendering "in whom" (that is, in Adam) shaped later Western doctrine.
- e (5:14) Adam: Hebrew, "man, humankind," related to *adamah*, "ground" (Gen 2:7).
- f (5:18) One righteous act: or "the righteous requirement of one."

Chapter 6

1 What then shall we say? Should we persist in sin so that grace may
multiply? 2 Absolutely not! We have died to sin; how can we still
continue in it? 3 Or are you unaware that all of us who were baptized[a]
into Christ Jesus[b] were baptized into his death? 4 So we were buried
with him through baptism into death, in order that, as Christ was
raised from the dead through the Father's glory, we too may live a
new kind of life. 5 For if we have grown together with him in the
likeness of his death, we will certainly also share in the likeness of his
resurrection. 6 This we know: our old humanity was crucified along
with him, to put out of action the sin-ruled body, so that we would
be slaves of sin no more. 7 For the one who has died has been set free[c]
from sin. 8 But if we died with Christ, we believe that we shall also
live with him, 9 knowing that Christ, now raised from the dead, will
never die again; death no longer lords it over him. 10 In dying, he died
to sin a single time for all; in living, he lives to God. 11 You too, then,
must count yourselves dead to sin but alive to God in Christ Jesus.[d]
12 So do not let sin reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its
cravings. 13 Do not keep offering the parts of your body to sin as tools[e]
of wickedness, but offer yourselves to God as people brought from
death to life, and your body's parts to God as tools of righteousness.
14 Sin will not rule over you, because you live not under law but under
grace.
15 What then? Shall we sin because we are not under law but under
grace? Never! 16 Surely you know that if you present yourselves to
anyone as slaves for obedience, you are that master's slaves whom
you obey, slaves either of sin, ending in death, or of obedience, ending
in righteousness. 17 But thanks be to God that you, once slaves of sin,
have obeyed from the heart the pattern of teaching to which you
were handed over; 18 and, set free from sin, you have been enslaved to
righteousness. 19 I speak in human fashion on account of your fleshly
weakness. As you once put your limbs and faculties in bondage to
uncleanness and lawlessness, for lawless ends,[f] so now put them in
bondage to righteousness, for holiness. 20 While you were sin's slaves,
righteousness had no claim on you. 21 And what harvest did you have

back then? Things that now make you ashamed, for those things end in death. 22 But now that you have been freed from sin and have become slaves of God, the fruit you reap leads to holiness, and its end is eternal life. 23 For the wages that sin pays are death, but God's free gift is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Notes

- a (6:3) Baptized: Greek *baptizō*, "dip, immerse, wash."
- b (6:3) Christ Jesus: "Jesus" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- c (6:7) Set free: Greek *dedikaiōtai*, literally "has been justified," here in the sense "acquitted" or "released."
- d (6:11) In Christ Jesus: many later manuscripts add "our Lord."
- e (6:13) Tools: or "weapons"; Greek *hopla*.
- f (6:19) For lawless ends: Greek "to lawlessness," bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.

Chapter 7

1 Or do you not realize, brothers (for I am speaking to people acquainted with law), that the law has authority over a person only as long as that person lives? 2 Take the married woman: the law binds her to her living husband, but should the husband die, she is discharged from the law concerning the husband. 3 So she will be labeled an adulteress if she takes up with another man while her husband is alive. But if her husband dies, the law no longer binds her, and she commits no adultery by marrying someone else. 4 In the same way, my brothers, you too were put to death to the law through the body of Christ, so as to belong to another, to him who was raised from the dead, in order that we might bear fruit for God. 5 For when we were in the flesh, the passions of sin, aroused through the law, were at work in our members to bear fruit for death. 6 Now, however, having died to what once held us fast, we have been discharged from the law, so as to be slaves in the newness of the Spirit and not in the oldness of the letter.

7 What are we to conclude? That the law is sinful? Certainly not! But I would never have recognized sin without the law. I would not have known about greed unless the law had said, "You must not covet."[a] 8 Sin, seizing the opening given by the commandment, worked in me

every kind of covetous desire. For apart from the law, sin lies dead. 9
Once, without law, I was living; but with the commandment's arrival
sin revived, and I died. 10 The very commandment that was meant for
life turned out for me to bring death. 11 For sin, seizing the opening
given by the commandment, deceived me and through it killed me. 12
The law, then, is holy; holy too is the commandment, and just, and
good.
13 Did what is good, then, become death to me? Never! It was sin, so
that it might be exposed as sin, that brought about my death through
what is good, so that through the commandment sin might become
sinful past all measure. 14 For we know that the law is spiritual; but I
am made of flesh,[b] sold as a slave under sin. 15 I do not grasp what I
am doing. For I do not carry out what I desire; instead I do the very
thing I loathe. 16 But when I do the thing I do not will, I am agreeing
that the law is fine. 17 So now it is no longer I who carry it out, but
sin that dwells in me. 18 For I know that nothing good dwells in me,
that is, in my flesh. The wanting is there in me, but the carrying out
of what is good is not. 19 For the good I want, I fail to do; but the evil
I do not want, that is what I keep doing. 20 And if what I am doing is
what I do not will, then the doer is no longer I, but the sin that has
its home in me.
21 This, then, is the law I find: when I want to do good, evil lies close
at hand. 22 For in my inner being I delight in the law of God, 23 but I
see another law in my members, waging war against the law of my
mind and taking me captive to the law of sin that is in my members.
24 What a miserable man I am! Who will deliver me out of this body
that is bound for death? 25 Thanks be[c] to God through Jesus Christ our
Lord! So then, I myself with my mind serve the law of God, but with
my flesh the law of sin.

Notes

- a (7:7) Exod 20:17; Deut 5:21.
- b (7:14) Made of flesh: Greek *sarkinos*; many later manuscripts read *sarkikos*, "fleshly."
- c (7:25) Thanks be: so the Westcott–Hort text (*charis* [*de*]). Many manuscripts read "I thank God"; others read "the grace of God" or "the grace of the Lord."

Chapter 8

1 There is therefore at present no sentence of condemnation against
those in Christ Jesus.[a] 2 For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ
Jesus has set you[b] free from the law of sin and of death. 3 The law
was powerless because of the flesh's weakness, but God did what it
could not: he sent his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, as a sin
offering,[c] and passed sentence on sin within the flesh, 4 so that the
righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk
not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit. 5 For those who
live according to the flesh set their minds on the things of the flesh,
but those who live according to the Spirit, on the things of the Spirit.
6 The mind of the flesh is death, but the mind of the Spirit is life and
peace, 7 for the flesh-minded outlook is at enmity with God; to God's
law it does not submit; indeed it is unable to. 8 Those who are in the
flesh cannot please God.

9 You, however, are not in flesh but in Spirit, provided that God's Spirit
makes his home in you. If someone lacks Christ's Spirit, that person
is not his. 10 Yet if Christ is within you, the body is a dead thing on
account of sin, but the Spirit is life on account of righteousness. 11 If
the Spirit of the one who raised Jesus from the dead lives in you, then
the one who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also bring your
mortal bodies to life, by means of his Spirit residing in you.[d]

12 So then, brothers, we are debtors, but not to the flesh, to live
according to the flesh. 13 For if you live by the flesh, you will die; but if
you use the Spirit to kill the practices of the body, you will live. 14 For
all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. 15 The spirit you
received was not one of slavery, plunging you back into fear; what
you received was the Spirit of sonship,[e] in whom we call out, "Abba!
[f] Father!" 16 The Spirit himself bears witness together with our spirit
that we are children of God, 17 and if we are children, we are heirs as
well: God's heirs, and Christ's co-heirs, if we share his suffering in
order to share his glory too.

18 In my reckoning, what we suffer in the present age does not deserve
to be set beside the glory about to be unveiled for us. 19 For the
creation waits with eager longing for the unveiling of the sons of

God. 20 For creation was placed under futility, not of its own will, but
on account of the one who placed it there, in hope[g] 21 that creation
itself will be freed from enslavement to corruption into the glorious
freedom of God's children. 22 For we know that the whole creation
has been groaning together and suffering birth pains together until
now. 23 Not that alone: we too, holding the Spirit as firstfruits, groan
within ourselves while we eagerly await adoption,[h] the redeeming of
our body. 24 It was in hope that we were saved. But a hope that is seen
is no hope. Who hopes for what is in plain sight?[i] 25 If our hope is for
what we do not see, we wait eagerly for it with perseverance.
26 Likewise the Spirit also helps us in our weakness. For we do not
know what we should pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself
intercedes with groanings too deep for words. 27 And the one who
examines our hearts knows the Spirit's intention, since the Spirit
pleads on behalf of God's holy people in line with God's will. 28 We
know that God works all things together[j] for the good of those who
love him, who are called in keeping with his purpose. 29 For those
whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image
of his Son, so that he might be the firstborn among many brothers. 30
Whom he predestined, these he called as well; whom he called, these
he justified as well; whom he justified, these he glorified as well.
31 What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who can be
against us? 32 He spared not even his own Son but handed him over
on behalf of us all. How then shall he fail to give us everything along
with him, as a gift? 33 Who will bring a charge against God's elect? It
is God who justifies. 34 Who is there to condemn? It is Christ Jesus[k]
who died, or rather was raised,[l] who sits at God's right hand, who
also pleads for us! 35 Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?[m]
Shall affliction, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness,
or danger, or sword? 36 As Scripture says, "On your account we face
death all day long; we are counted as sheep for slaughter."[n] 37 No, in all
these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us.
38 I am persuaded that not death, not life, not angels, not principalities,
not the present, not the future, not powers, 39 not height, not depth,

nor any other created thing will have power to part us from God's love in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Notes

- a (8:1) In Christ Jesus: many later manuscripts add "who walk not according to the flesh," and some add further "but according to the Spirit" (compare v. 4).
- b (8:2) You: so the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts read "me," others "us."
- c (8:3) As an offering for sin: or simply "concerning sin"; the Greek phrase *peri hamartias* often renders "sin offering" in the Greek Old Testament.
- d (8:11) Through his Spirit dwelling in you: so the Westcott–Hort text (genitive); many manuscripts read "because of his Spirit dwelling in you" (accusative). "Also" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- e (8:15) Sonship: Greek *huiothesia*, a legal term for adoption granting full rights of inheritance.
- f (8:15) Abba: Aramaic, "father."
- g (8:20) In hope: or, joining to v. 21, "in hope, because the creation itself…"
- h (8:23) Adoption: a few witnesses, including P46 and Bezae (as reported), lack "adoption." "We" (*hēmeis*) after "firstfruits" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- i (8:24) Who hopes for what is in plain sight?: some manuscripts read "why does anyone still hope for what he sees?"; others "why does anyone still wait for what he sees?"
- j (8:28) All things work together: so the Westcott–Hort text in its main reading; "God" is printed in brackets after it, from P46, Alexandrinus, Vaticanus, and a few others (as reported), giving "God works all things together for good" or "in all things God works for good." Grammatically, "all things" may also be the object, with the Spirit (v. 27) as subject: "he works all things together for good."
- k (8:34) Christ Jesus: "Jesus" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- l (8:34) Raised: "from the dead" is added in brackets in the Westcott–Hort text, following Sinaiticus (original hand) and others (as reported).
- m (8:35) Of Christ: Sinaiticus reads "of God"; Vaticanus reads "of God in Christ Jesus" (as reported).
- n (8:36) Ps 44:22 (43:23 Greek).

Chapter 9

1 I am speaking the truth in Christ; I am not lying, as my conscience confirms by the Holy Spirit: 2 I carry a great sorrow and an unceasing anguish in my heart. 3 I could pray to be accursed[a] myself, severed from Christ, on behalf of my brothers, my own flesh-and-blood kin. 4 They are Israelites;[b] theirs are the adoption, the glory, the covenants,

the giving of the law, the worship, and the promises; 5 theirs are the
patriarchs, and from them, by physical descent, comes the Messiah,
who is God over all, blessed forever. Amen.[c]
6 But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who
are descended from Israel are Israel, 7 nor are they all Abraham's
children because they are his offspring; rather, "Through Isaac[d] your
offspring will be named."[e] 8 That is, it is not the children of the flesh
who are God's children, but the children of the promise are counted
as offspring. 9 For this was the wording of the promise: "At this season
I will return, and Sarah will have a son."[f] 10 And not only so, but
Rebekah too conceived children by one man, our forefather Isaac. 11
For before they were born, before they had done anything either good
or worthless, in order that God's electing purpose might remain in
force, resting not on deeds but on the one who calls, 12 it was said to
her, "The elder shall be slave to the younger."[g] 13 As it is written, "Jacob
I loved, but Esau I hated."[h]
14 What then shall we say? Is there injustice with God? Never! 15 For he
says to Moses, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will
have compassion on whom I have compassion."[i] 16 So then it does not
depend on human willing or running, but on God who shows mercy.
17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh, "For this very purpose I raised
you up, to display my power in you, and so that my name might be
proclaimed in all the earth."[j] 18 So, then, he shows mercy to whom he
chooses, and to whom he chooses he gives a hard heart.
19 You will say to me then, "Why does he still find fault? For who
resists his will?" 20 But rather, O man, who are you to answer God
back? Shall the thing formed say to the one who formed it, "Why have
you made me this way?"[k] 21 Has the potter not the authority over his
clay to make from a single lump this pot for an honored purpose and
that one for an ordinary purpose? 22 What if God, wanting to show
his wrath and make known his power, endured with much patience
vessels of wrath made ready for destruction, 23 and did so to make
the wealth of his glory known upon vessels of mercy, prepared in
advance for glory: 24 namely us, whom he also called, not only from
among the Jews but also from among the Gentiles? 25 So he says in

Hosea[l] also, "The people not mine I will name 'My people,' and the one not loved I will name 'Loved.'[m] 26 And in the very place where it was said to them, 'You are not my people,' there they will be called sons of the living God."[n] 27 And Isaiah[o] proclaims about Israel: "Even if Israel's people are as many as the sand by the sea, only a remnant will be rescued; 28 for the Lord will execute his word upon the earth, bringing it to an end and cutting it short."[p] 29 And as Isaiah foretold, "Had not the Lord of Hosts left us a seed, we would have fared as Sodom did, and resembled Gomorrah."[q]

30 What should we say, then? That non-Jews, who were not chasing after righteousness, have grasped righteousness, the righteousness that comes through faith; 31 but Israel, pursuing a law of righteousness, did not attain to that law. 32 Why? Because they did not pursue it from faith, but as though it were from works.[r] They stumbled over the stone of stumbling, 33 just as Scripture says, "Look, I place in Zion a stone that makes people stumble, a rock that trips them up; and the one who trusts in him will not be disgraced."[s]

Notes

- a (9:3) Accursed: Greek *anathema*, devoted to destruction.
- b (9:4) Israelites: *Israel*, the name given to Jacob, is explained in Gen 32:28 as "he strives with God."
- c (9:5) The Messiah, who is God over all, blessed forever. Amen: the punctuation is disputed, and early manuscripts lack punctuation. The Westcott–Hort text prints a comma after "descent," as rendered here; its margin offers a full stop there, so that the next sentence becomes a separate doxology: "God, who is over all, be blessed forever. Amen." Other possible punctuations make "who is over all" describe the Messiah, with a separate sentence praising God, or make "God" a further title of the Messiah in the same sentence.
- d (9:7) Isaac: Hebrew, "he laughs" (Gen 17:17–19; 21:6).
- e (9:7) Gen 21:12.
- f (9:9) Gen 18:10, 14.
- g (9:12) Gen 25:23.
- h (9:13) Mal 1:2–3.
- i (9:15) Exod 33:19.
- j (9:17) Exod 9:16.
- k (9:20) Isa 29:16; 45:9.
- l (9:25) Hosea: Hebrew, "salvation."
- m (9:25) Hos 2:23.

- n (9:26) Hos 1:10.
- o (9:27) Isaiah: Hebrew, "Yahweh is salvation."
- p (9:28) Isa 10:22–23, following the Greek Old Testament; compare Hos 1:10. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is "the Lord Yahweh of Hosts." Many later manuscripts expand v. 28: "for he will finish the matter and cut it short in righteousness, because the Lord will make a short work upon the earth."
- q (9:29) Isa 1:9. Greek *Kyrios Sabaōth*, for Hebrew *Yahweh Tseva'ot*, Yahweh of the armies (of heaven). Sodom and Gomorrah: Gen 19:24–25.
- r (9:32) From works: many later manuscripts add "of the law."
- s (9:33) Isa 28:16 combined with Isa 8:14.

Chapter 10

1 Brothers, my heart's goodwill and my plea to God on their behalf
is for their salvation. 2 I can testify for them that they have zeal for
God, though not a zeal guided by knowledge. 3 Not recognizing the
righteousness that comes from God, and seeking to set up their own,
they did not yield to God's righteousness. 4 For Christ is the goal[a] of
the law, bringing righteousness to everyone who believes.
5 For Moses describes law-based righteousness this way: "Whoever
does these things shall live by them."[b] 6 But the righteousness based on
faith speaks this way: "Do not say in your heart, 'Who will climb up
into heaven?'" (that is, to bring Christ down), 7 "or, 'Who will go down
into the abyss?'" (that is, to bring Christ up from among the dead). 8
But what does it say? "The word is close to you, on your lips and in
your heart"[c] (that is, the word of faith that we proclaim): 9 that if with
your mouth you confess Jesus as Lord, and in your heart believe that
God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. 10 For one believes
with the heart and so is made righteous, and one confesses with the
mouth and so is saved. 11 For the Scripture says, "No one who puts his
trust in him will be put to shame."[d] 12 There is no difference between
Jew and Greek; the same Lord is Lord of all, and pours out his riches
on all who call upon him. 13 For "everyone who calls upon the name
of the Lord will be saved."[e]
14 But how can people call upon him without first believing in him?
And how believe in him if they never heard of him? And how hear of
him with no one proclaiming? 15 And how are people to herald unless
they are sent? As it is written, "How lovely are the feet of those who

announce good news!"[f] 16 But not everyone has obeyed the good news.
For Isaiah asks, "Lord, who has trusted our message?"[g] 17 Faith, then,
arises from hearing the message, and the message comes by the word
of Christ.[h] 18 But, I ask, is it that they never heard? Of course they
heard: "Their sound went forth into every land, and their sayings to
the far reaches of the world."[i] 19 But I ask, did Israel not understand?
First Moses says, "I will provoke you to jealousy by what is no nation;
by a senseless nation I will rouse you to anger."[j] 20 And Isaiah grows
bold and says, "I was found by those who were not seeking me; I
became plain to see for those who were not asking for me."[k] 21 But of
Israel he says, "All day long I have held out my hands to a disobedient
and contrary people."[l]

Notes

- a (10:4) Goal: Greek *telos*, "end, goal, culmination"; often understood as "end" in the sense of termination.
- b (10:5) Lev 18:5.
- c (10:8) Deut 30:12–14.
- d (10:11) Isa 28:16.
- e (10:13) Joel 2:32 (3:5 Hebrew). In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh; Paul applies the verse to Jesus as Lord (vv. 9, 12).
- f (10:15) Isa 52:7; compare Nah 1:15. Many later manuscripts expand the quotation: "…of those who announce the gospel of peace, who announce good news of good things."
- g (10:16) Isa 53:1, following the Greek Old Testament; "Lord" is not in the Hebrew text.
- h (10:17) Of Christ: many later manuscripts read "of God."
- i (10:18) Ps 19:4 (18:5 Greek).
- j (10:19) Deut 32:21.
- k (10:20) Isa 65:1.
- l (10:21) Isa 65:2.

Chapter 11

1 I ask, then, has God rejected his people? Never! For I myself am an
Israelite, a descendant of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin.[a] 2 No,
God has not cast off his people whom he knew in advance. Do you
not know what Scripture says in the story of Elijah,[b] when he appeals
to God against Israel? 3 "Lord, your prophets they have put to death,
your altars they have demolished; I am the only one remaining, and

now they want my life."[c] 4 But what is the divine answer to him? "I
have kept for myself seven thousand men who have not bent the knee
to Baal."[d] 5 Just so, in this present time too, a remnant exists, selected
by grace. 6 But if by grace, then not from works, or grace would cease
to be grace.[e]
7 What then? What Israel is seeking, it has not obtained. The elect
obtained it, but the rest were hardened, 8 just as Scripture says, "God
has given them a numbed spirit, eyes for not seeing and ears for not
hearing, up to this present day."[f] 9 David also says, "May their table
turn into a net and a snare, a cause of stumbling and a payback to
them; 10 may their eyes grow dark, unable to see, and may you keep
their backs bowed forever."[g]
11 So I ask, did they stumble in order to fall? Never! Rather, through
their trespass salvation has come to the Gentiles, to provoke Israel to
jealousy. 12 If their false step is wealth for the world, and their loss is
wealth for the Gentiles, what will their fullness be?
13 Now I am speaking to you Gentiles. Inasmuch as I am an apostle
to the Gentiles, I make much of my ministry 14 in the hope that I
may somehow provoke my own people[h] to jealousy and save some of
them. 15 If casting them away brings the world's reconciliation, what
will receiving them back bring, if not life out of death? 16 If the portion
of dough offered as firstfruits is holy, so is the whole batch; and if the
root is holy, so are the branches.
17 Now if certain branches were snapped off, and you, being wild olive,
were grafted in among the rest and became a sharer in the rich sap
of the olive's root, 18 do not look down on the branches. If you do,
remember that you do not hold up the root; the root holds up you. 19
"But," you will say, "branches were snapped off to make room for me
to be grafted in." 20 Quite so: they were snapped off for unbelief, while
you hold your place through faith. So do not think proud thoughts;
fear instead. 21 If God did not spare the branches that grew there by
nature, he will not spare you either.[i] 22 Consider, then, God's kindness
and his severity: severity toward those who fell, but toward you God's
kindness, provided you continue in that kindness; otherwise you too
will be cut off. 23 And they too, if they do not remain in unbelief, will

be grafted in, for God is able to graft them in again. 24 You were cut
out of an olive that grows wild by nature and grafted, contrary to
nature, into a garden olive; how much more readily will these natural
branches be grafted back into the tree that is their own!
25 For I would not have you uninformed, brothers, about this mystery,
so that you do not think yourselves wise: a partial hardening has
befallen Israel until the Gentiles in their full number have come in;
26 and so all Israel will be saved, just as Scripture says, "Out of Zion
will come the Rescuer, and he will banish ungodliness from Jacob.[j]
27 and this will be my covenant with them, when I take away their
sins."[k] 28 With respect to the gospel, they are opposed to God for your
benefit; but with respect to election, they are loved because of their
ancestors. 29 For the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable. 30 Just
as you once defied God but have now been shown mercy through
their defiance, 31 so they too have now been disobedient, so that by
the mercy shown to you they also may now[l] receive mercy. 32 For God
has shut up all people together in disobedience, so that he may have
mercy on all.
33 Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God!
How unsearchable are his judgments, and how untraceable his ways!
34 "For who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his
counselor?"[m] 35 "Or who has given him a gift first, so that he must be
repaid?"[n] 36 For from him and through him and to him are all things.
To him be the glory forever. Amen.

Notes

- a (11:1) Benjamin: Hebrew, "son of the right hand" (Gen 35:18).
- b (11:2) Elijah: Hebrew, "my God is Yahweh."
- c (11:3) 1 Kgs 19:10, 14. "Lord" is not in the Hebrew text.
- d (11:4) 1 Kgs 19:18.
- e (11:6) Grace would cease to be grace: many later manuscripts add, "But if it is by works, it is no longer grace; otherwise work is no longer work."
- f (11:8) Deut 29:4; Isa 29:10.
- g (11:10) Ps 69:22–23 (68:23–24 Greek).
- h (11:14) My own people: literally "my flesh."
- i (11:21) He will not spare you either: many manuscripts read "perhaps he will not spare you either."
- j (11:26) Jacob: Hebrew, "he grasps the heel" (Gen 25:26), hence "he supplants."

- k (11:27) Isa 59:20–21; 27:9.
- l (11:31) Now: lacking in P46 and many other manuscripts (as reported); some read “later.”
- m (11:34) Isa 40:13, following the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.
- n (11:35) Job 41:11 (41:3 Hebrew).

Chapter 12

1 So I urge you, brothers and sisters, by God’s mercies, to offer your
bodies as a living sacrifice, set apart and pleasing to God; this is your
rational[a] worship. 2 Stop being molded by the pattern of this age, and
be changed by a renewed mind, so that you can test and recognize
God’s will: what is good, acceptable, and complete.
3 Through the grace granted me I say to every one of you: do not rate
yourself above what is fitting, but rate yourself soberly, in keeping
with the measure of faith God has allotted each. 4 For just as in one
body we have many parts, and the parts do not all have the same
function, 5 so we, many as we are, are one body in Christ, and individ-
ually we are parts of one another. 6 We have gifts that differ according
to the grace given us. If prophecy, let it be in proportion to our faith;
7 if service, in serving; the one who teaches, in teaching; 8 whoever
exhorts, by exhorting; whoever gives, generously;[b] whoever governs,
diligently; whoever shows compassion, cheerfully.
9 Let love be free of pretense. Loathe what is evil; cling to what
is good. 10 In brotherly love be warmly devoted to one another; in
showing honor, go ahead of one another. 11 Do not lag in zeal; be
aglow with the Spirit;[c] serve the Lord.[d] 12 Rejoice in hope, hold firm
in affliction, persist in prayer. 13 Contribute to the needs of the saints;
pursue hospitality. 14 Bless those who persecute you;[e] bless and do
not curse. 15 Rejoice with people who rejoice; weep with people who
weep. 16 Be of one mind toward one another. Do not set your mind
on lofty things, but associate with the lowly.[f] Do not be wise in your
own estimation. 17 Pay back no one evil for evil. Give thought to what
is honorable in the sight of all people. 18 As far as possible, and as
far as it rests with you, live peaceably with all. 19 Never take revenge
yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s[g] wrath; for it is written,

“Vengeance is mine; I will repay, says the Lord.”[h] 20 Instead, “if your enemy is hungry, give him food; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink; for in doing this you will pile burning coals on his head.”[i] 21 Do not let evil overpower you; overpower evil with good.

Notes

- a (12:1) Reasonable: Greek *logikos*, “rational, spiritual”; or “true and proper.”
- b (12:8) With generosity: or “with sincerity, single-mindedness.”
- c (12:11) Be aglow with the Spirit: or “be fervent in spirit.”
- d (12:11) The Lord: some Western manuscripts read “the time,” that is, “serve the opportune moment.”
- e (12:14) Persecute you: “you” is lacking in P46 and Vaticanus (as reported).
- f (12:16) Associate with the lowly: or “give yourselves to humble tasks.”
- g (12:19) God’s: not in the Greek, which reads “the wrath,” most likely meaning God’s.
- h (12:19) Deut 32:35. “Says the Lord” is not in the Hebrew or Greek text of Deuteronomy, where Yahweh is the speaker.
- i (12:20) Prov 25:21–22.

Chapter 13

1 Every soul must submit to the authorities that hold power over it. No authority exists apart from God, and the authorities that are have been appointed by God. 2 So whoever sets himself against the authority is resisting what God has ordained, and those who resist will bring judgment on themselves. 3 For rulers hold no fear for those who do right, only for wrongdoers. Would you like to live free of fear toward the authority? Then keep doing good, and you will receive its praise; 4 for it serves God for your benefit. But if you do wrong, you should fear, because it does not bear the sword without purpose; it serves God as an executor of punishment on the one who does wrong. 5 So you must submit, not merely out of fear of punishment but also because of your conscience. 6 For the same reason you pay tribute; the authorities are ministers of God, and they give themselves continually to just this task. 7 Pay to all what is owed them: tax to whom tax is owed, revenue to whom revenue, respect to whom respect, honor to whom honor.

8 Owe no one anything, except to love one another; for whoever loves the other has fulfilled the law. 9 For the commandments, “You shall not

commit adultery, you shall not murder, you shall not steal, you shall not covet,"[a] and any other commandment there may be, are summed up in this word: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself."[b] 10 Love does no wrong to a neighbor; love, then, is the law's fulfillment.
11 And do it as people who understand the season, that the hour has already struck for you[c] to wake out of sleep; our salvation is closer now than at the time we came to faith. 12 The night is far gone; the day is close at hand. So let us lay aside the works of darkness and put on the armor of light. 13 Let us walk with decency, as in the daytime, not in revelry and drunkenness, not in sexual immorality and debauchery, not in quarreling and jealousy. 14 Instead, clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its cravings.

Notes

- a (13:9) Exod 20:13–15, 17; Deut 5:17–19, 21. Many later manuscripts add "you shall not bear false witness."
- b (13:9) Lev 19:18.
- c (13:11) You: many manuscripts read "us."

Chapter 14

1 As for the person who is weak in faith, welcome him, but not for the purpose of passing judgment on his scruples. 2 One man believes he may eat everything; another, being weak, lives on vegetables. 3 The one who eats must not look down on the one who abstains, and the one who abstains must not sit in judgment on the one who eats; for God has welcomed him. 4 Who are you to condemn somebody else's house slave? His standing or falling concerns his own master. And he will be held upright, for the Lord[a] is able to keep him standing. 5 One person rates one day above another, while another rates all days alike. Let each be fully settled in his own mind. 6 Whoever keeps a special day keeps it to honor the Lord.[b] Whoever eats, eats to honor the Lord, for he thanks God; and whoever refrains, refrains to honor the Lord, and he too thanks God. 7 Not one of us has his life for himself alone, and not one of us has his death for himself alone. 8 If we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. Whether we live, then, or whether we die, we are the Lord's. 9 For this purpose Christ

died and came to life again: to be Lord over the dead and the living alike. 10 Why, then, do you judge your fellow believer? And you, why do you look down on your fellow believer? All of us will stand before God's tribunal.[c] 11 For scripture says, "By my life, says the Lord, every knee will bow to me, and every tongue will confess God."[d] 12 Each one of us, then, will render to God[e] a reckoning for himself.

13 So let us stop judging one another, and decide instead never to place an obstacle or trap in a fellow believer's way. 14 I know, and am convinced in the Lord Jesus, that nothing is unclean in itself; but to anyone who regards something as unclean, to him it is unclean. 15 For if your brother is grieved because of what you eat, you are no longer walking by love. Do not by your food destroy that person for whom Christ died. 16 Do not let your good be slandered as evil. 17 God's kingdom does not consist in food and drink; it is righteousness, peace and joy in the Holy Spirit. 18 Anyone who serves Christ like this finds favor with God and wins people's esteem. 19 So then let us pursue[f] the things that make for peace and for building one another up. 20 Do not tear down the work of God for the sake of food. Everything is indeed clean, but it is wrong for a person to eat in a way that makes another stumble. 21 The right thing is to abstain from meat and wine and anything else that trips up your brother.[g] 22 Hold the faith you have as a matter between yourself and God. Blessed is the one who need not judge himself over what he allows. 23 But the one who has doubts is condemned if he eats, because he does not act from faith; and whatever does not come from faith is sin.[h]

Notes

- a (14:4) The Lord: many manuscripts read "God."
- b (14:6) For the Lord: many later manuscripts add "and the one who does not observe the day does not observe it for the Lord."
- c (14:10) Of God: many later manuscripts read "of Christ."
- d (14:11) Isa 49:18; 45:23. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh. Or "shall confess to God."
- e (14:12) To God: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; lacking in Vaticanus and some others (as reported).
- f (14:19) Let us pursue: many manuscripts read "we pursue."

- g (14:21) Trips up your brother: many manuscripts add “or is offended or is made weak.”
- h (14:23) Is sin: many later manuscripts, followed by the Robinson–Pierpont text, place the doxology of 16:25–27 here; some witnesses have it both here and at the end of chapter 16. The Latin evidence and Marcion (as reported by Origen) point to a form of the letter that ended at 14:23. See the note at 16:25.

Chapter 15

1 We, the strong, are bound to carry the frailties of those without
strength, rather than to gratify ourselves. 2 Each of us should seek to
satisfy his neighbor, aiming at what is good and builds up. 3 Christ
himself did not seek his own satisfaction; rather, as Scripture says,
“The reproaches of those reproaching you landed on me.”[a] 4 All that
was written long ago was written to teach us, so that by the stead-
fastness and comfort the Scriptures give we might hold on to hope.
5 May the God of endurance and encouragement grant you to be of
one mind with one another, in keeping with Christ Jesus, 6 so that
together, with one voice, you may glorify the God and Father of our
Lord Jesus Christ.
7 Welcome one another, therefore, just as Christ also welcomed you,[b]
for the glory of God. 8 I declare that Christ became a minister to the
circumcision for the sake of God’s truth, to make good the promises
given to the patriarchs, 9 and so that the Gentiles might glorify God
for his mercy. As it is written, “For this reason I will praise you among
the Gentiles, and sing to your name.”[c] 10 And again it says, “Rejoice,
you Gentiles, with his people.”[d] 11 And again, “Praise the Lord, all you
Gentiles, and let all the peoples extol him.”[e] 12 And Isaiah says again,
“There will be a shoot from the root of Jesse,[f] one who stands up to
govern the nations; the nations will place their hope in him.”[g] 13 Now
may the God who gives hope fill you with every joy and peace as you
believe, until hope overflows in you through the Holy Spirit’s power.
14 I myself am convinced about you, my brothers, that you yourselves
are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, and able to instruct one
another. 15 Still, I have written to you in places with some daring, as
one who refreshes your memory, through the grace God gave me 16 to
serve as Christ Jesus’ minister to the nations, working as a priest for

God's gospel, so that the nations may become an acceptable offering,
made holy by the Holy Spirit. 17 So I have grounds for pride in Christ
Jesus regarding my work for God. 18 I will not presume to mention
anything but what Christ has done by my means to win the Gentiles'
obedience, in speech and in action, 19 with mighty signs and wonders,
in the might of the Spirit;[h] so it is that, from Jerusalem round in a
circle as far as Illyricum,[i] I have fully proclaimed Christ's gospel. 20
It has been my aim to proclaim the good news where Christ's name
was not yet known, so as not to build on foundations someone else
had laid, 21 rather, as Scripture says, "People to whom no word of him
came shall see, and people who never heard shall understand."[j]
22 That is what has so many times kept me from reaching you. 23
Now, though, with no further scope for me in these parts, and with
a longing these many years to visit you, 24 I hope, when I journey to
Spain,[k] to see you on the way and to be helped on my journey by you,
after first enjoying your fellowship a little. 25 For now, though, I am
traveling to Jerusalem in the service of the saints. 26 Macedonia and
Achaia[l] have gladly resolved to share their resources with the poor
among Jerusalem's saints. 27 They resolved it gladly, and they owe it
to them; for since the Gentiles have shared in their spiritual goods,
they are bound to render them service in earthly goods as well. 28 So
once I have finished this and have made sure they receive this fruit,[m]
I will leave for Spain and pass through your city. 29 I know that when
I come to you, I will come in the fullness of the blessing of Christ.[n]
30 I appeal to you, brothers,[o] by our Lord Jesus Christ and by the love
of the Spirit, to strive together with me in your prayers to God on my
behalf, 31 Pray that I may be kept safe from the disobedient in Judea,
and that the aid I bring to Jerusalem may be well received by the
saints, 32 so that, God willing, I may reach you joyfully and find rest
with you. 33 May the God of peace be with you all. Amen.[p]

Notes

- a (15:3) Ps 69:9 (68:10 Greek).
- b (15:7) You: many manuscripts read "us."
- c (15:9) 2 Sam 22:50; Ps 18:49 (17:50 Greek).
- d (15:10) Deut 32:43, following the Greek Old Testament.

- e (15:11) Ps 117:1 (116:1 Greek). In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.
- f (15:12) Jesse: the father of King David (1 Sam 16:1).
- g (15:12) Isa 11:10, following the Greek Old Testament.
- h (15:19) Spirit: “Holy” is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; many manuscripts read “the Spirit of God,” and Vaticanus reads “the Spirit” (as reported).
- i (15:19) Illyricum: a Roman province on the eastern coast of the Adriatic Sea, roughly modern Albania, Montenegro, Bosnia, and Croatia.
- j (15:21) Isa 52:15, following the Greek Old Testament.
- k (15:24) Spain: many later manuscripts add “I will come to you.”
- l (15:26) Macedonia and Achaia: Roman provinces in northern and southern Greece.
- m (15:28) Made sure they receive this fruit: literally “sealed to them this fruit.”
- n (15:29) Of Christ: many later manuscripts read “of the gospel of Christ.”
- o (15:30) Brothers: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; lacking in P46 and Vaticanus (as reported).
- p (15:33) Amen: lacking in some manuscripts. P46 places the doxology of 16:25–27 here, after 15:33, and then continues with chapter 16 (as reported). See the note at 16:25.

Chapter 16

1 I introduce to you our sister Phoebe,[a] who also serves as a minister[b]
of the congregation at Cenchreae,[c] 2 asking you to receive her in the
Lord in a way worthy of the saints and to stand by her in whatever
matter she may need you; for she herself has been a patron[d] of many,
and of me as well.
3 Give my greetings to Prisca and Aquila,[e] my co-workers in Christ
Jesus, 4 who put their own necks on the line to save my life. Not only
I give thanks for them, but every one of the Gentile churches does
too. 5 Greet also the church that meets in their house. Greet my dear
Epaenetus,[f] the first convert in Asia[g] to Christ. 6 Greet Mary, who has
toiled hard on your behalf. 7 Greet Andronicus and Junia,[h] my kin
and once my fellow prisoners. They are eminent among the apostles,[i]
and they were in Christ before me. 8 Greet Ampliatus, my dear friend
in the Lord. 9 Greet Urbanus, our fellow worker in Christ, and my
dear Stachys. 10 Greet Apelles, tried and proven in Christ. Greet the
members of the household of Aristobulus. 11 Greet Herodion, my
kinsman. Greet those in Narcissus’s household who are in the Lord.
12 Greet those workers in the Lord, Tryphaena and Tryphosa.[j] Greet

dear Persis, who has labored hard in the Lord. 13 Greet Rufus,[k] the
Lord's chosen one, and his mother, who has mothered me as well.
14 Greet Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas, and the
brothers with them. 15 Greet Philologus and Julia, Nereus and his
sister, and Olympas, and all the saints with them. 16 Greet one another
with a holy kiss. All the churches of Christ send you greetings.
17 I urge you, brothers, keep an eye on those who stir up divisions and
set traps contrary to the teaching you learned; steer clear of them. 18
Such people are not slaves of our Lord Christ but of their own belly,
and by smooth talk and flattery they lead astray the hearts of the
unsuspecting. 19 Everyone has heard how obedient you are, and that
makes me glad for you; still, I would have you skilled in goodness and
untainted by evil. 20 The God of peace will soon crush Satan[l] beneath
your feet. The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you.[m]
21 Timothy,[n] my fellow worker, sends you greetings, as do Lucius,
Jason, and Sosipater, my kinsmen. 22 I, Tertius,[o] who wrote this letter
down, send you greetings in the Lord. 23 Greetings to you from Gaius,
my host and host of the entire church. Erastus, treasurer of the city,
sends greetings, and so does Quartus, our brother. 24 [p]
25 Now to him who is able to make you firm according to my gospel
and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of
the mystery kept in silence for long ages[q] 26 but now brought to light,
and through the prophetic writings, by command of the eternal God,
made known to all the Gentiles to bring about the obedience of faith:
27 to God, who alone is wise, be[r] glory through Jesus Christ forever
and ever. Amen.

Notes

- a (16:1) Phoebe: Greek, "bright, radiant."
- b (16:1) Minister: Greek *diakonos*, "servant, minister," also used of the church office of deacon (Phil 1:1; 1 Tim 3:8–13).
- c (16:1) Cenchreae: the eastern port of Corinth.
- d (16:2) Patron: Greek *prostatis*, a benefactor, protector, or leader.
- e (16:3) Prisca and Aquila: *Prisca* (diminutive *Priscilla*, Acts 18:2) is Latin, "ancient, venerable"; *Aquila* is Latin, "eagle."
- f (16:5) Epaenetus: Greek, "praised."

- g (16:5) Asia: the Roman province in western Asia Minor. Many later manuscripts read "Achaia."
- h (16:7) Junia: a common Latin woman's name, so understood by early Christian writers, including John Chrysostom (as reported). Medieval and later interpreters often read the Greek accusative *Iounian* as the man's name "Junias," which is not otherwise attested; the unaccented Westcott–Hort text allows either. P46 and a few other witnesses read "Julia" (as reported).
- i (16:7) Eminent among the apostles: or "well known to the apostles." The Greek phrase can mean either that they were outstanding apostles or that the apostles held them in high regard.
- j (16:12) Tryphaena and Tryphosa: Greek, "dainty" and "delicate"; perhaps sisters.
- k (16:13) Rufus: Latin, "red"; perhaps the son of Simon of Cyrene (Mark 15:21).
- l (16:20) Satan: Hebrew, "adversary."
- m (16:20) The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you: lacking in Bezae and some other Western witnesses (as reported), which place a similar benediction at v. 24 instead.
- n (16:21) Timothy: Greek, "one who honors God."
- o (16:22) Tertius: Latin, "third." Quartus (v. 23) is Latin, "fourth."
- p (16:24) The Westcott–Hort text, with P46, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus, Vaticanus and others (as reported), lacks v. 24. Many later manuscripts include it: "The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen." Some place it after v. 27.
- q (16:25) Kept in silence for long ages: vv. 25–27, the closing doxology, stand here in P61, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Ephraemi, Bezae, and others; after 14:23 in most later manuscripts; after 15:33 in P46; in both places in Alexandrinus and a few others; and nowhere in Codices Augiensis and Boernerianus (as reported). Its varying position suggests that the letter circulated in shorter forms, and many scholars judge the doxology to have been added by a later hand.
- r (16:27) Be: the Westcott–Hort text includes, in brackets, *hō*, "to whom," which leaves the sentence grammatically incomplete: "to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory forever." Vaticanus and a few others lack it (as reported).

1 Corinthians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul, called by God's will to be an apostle of Christ Jesus, and
from Sosthenes[a] our brother, 2 to the church of God that is in Corinth,[b]
to those made holy in Christ Jesus, called to be saints, together with
all who in every place call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, their
Lord and ours: 3 grace to you and peace from God our Father and the
Lord Jesus Christ.
4 I give thanks to my God at all times on your account, for the grace of
God granted you in Christ Jesus; 5 for in him you have been enriched
in every respect, in all your speaking and all your understanding, 6
just as the testimony about Christ was made firm among you, 7 so
that you lack no gift of grace as you eagerly await the unveiling of
our Lord Jesus Christ. 8 He will keep you steady to the very end,
beyond reproach on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.[c] 9 Faithful is
God, through whom you were called into fellowship with his Son,
Jesus Christ our Lord.
10 I appeal to you, brothers and sisters, in the name of our Lord
Jesus Christ: agree among yourselves, have no factions, and be joined
together with a shared outlook and purpose. 11 For Chloe's[d] household
have reported to me, my brothers and sisters, that there are disputes
among you. 12 What I mean is this: each of you says, "I belong to
Paul," or "I to Apollos,"[e] or "I to Cephas,"[f] or "I to Christ." 13 Has Christ
been parceled out? Was Paul crucified on your behalf? Or were you
baptized into Paul's name? 14 I am thankful[g] that I baptized none of
you except Crispus and Gaius, 15 so no one can say that you were
baptized into my name. 16 (I did baptize the household of Stephanas[h]
too; beyond that, I do not recall baptizing anyone else.) 17 For Christ
did not commission me to baptize but to announce the good news,

and not through polished rhetoric, lest the cross of Christ be emptied of its force.

18 For the message[i] of the cross is foolishness to those on the way to destruction, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.
19 For it is written, "I will destroy the wisdom of the wise, and the shrewdness of the shrewd I will set aside."[j] 20 Where is the wise man? Where is the scribe? Where is the debater of this age? Has God not made foolish the wisdom of the world? 21 For since the world, surrounded by God's wisdom, did not come to know God through its own wisdom, God chose to rescue believers by means of the apparent absurdity of the proclamation. 22 Jews ask for signs and Greeks look for wisdom, 23 but we proclaim Christ crucified, an offense to Jews and folly to Gentiles, 24 but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God. 25 For God's folly is wiser than human beings, and God's weakness is stronger than human beings.

26 Just look at your own calling, brothers: not many of you were wise by worldly standards, not many powerful, not many of noble birth. 27 But God chose what is foolish in the world to put the wise to shame; God chose what is weak in the world to put the strong to shame;
28 God chose what is lowborn in the world and what is despised, things that are not, to bring to nothing things that are, 29 so that no human being might boast before God. 30 It is from him that you are in Christ Jesus, who became for us wisdom from God, and righteousness and holiness and redemption, 31 so that it may be as Scripture says: "Whoever boasts, let him make his boast in the Lord."[k]

Notes

- a (1:1) Sosthenes: Greek, "safe in strength"; perhaps the synagogue ruler of Acts 18:17.
- b (1:2) Corinth: a Roman colony and capital of the province of Achaia, on the isthmus between mainland Greece and the Peloponnese.
- c (1:8) Jesus Christ: "Christ" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- d (1:11) Chloe: Greek, "green shoot," a name of the goddess Demeter.
- e (1:12) Apollos: a short form of *Apollonius*, from the god Apollo; a Jewish Christian teacher from Alexandria (Acts 18:24–28).

- f (1:12) Cephas: Aramaic *Kepha*, “rock,” rendered in Greek as *Petros*, Peter (John 1:42).
- g (1:14) I am thankful: so the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus (original hand) and Vaticanus (as reported); most manuscripts read “I thank God.”
- h (1:16) Stephanas: Greek, “crown.”
- i (1:18) Message: Greek *logos*, “word.”
- j (1:19) Isa 29:14, following the Greek Old Testament.
- k (1:31) Jer 9:24. In the Hebrew text, “the Lord” is Yahweh.

Chapter 2

1 For my part, brothers, when I came to you, I did not come with any
superiority of speech or wisdom as I proclaimed to you the mystery[a]
of God. 2 For I made up my mind to know nothing among you except
Jesus Christ, and him crucified. 3 And I came among you in weakness
and fear and much trembling, 4 and my speech and my proclamation
were not in persuasive words of wisdom,[b] but in a demonstration of
the Spirit and of power, 5 so that your faith would rest not on human
wisdom but on God’s power.
6 Yet among the mature we do speak wisdom, though not a wisdom of
this age, nor of the rulers of this age, who are passing away. 7 Rather,
we speak God’s wisdom in a mystery, the hidden wisdom that God
foreordained before the ages for our glory. 8 This wisdom not one of
the rulers of this age has grasped; had they grasped it, they would
never have crucified the Lord of glory. 9 But, as it is written, “What
no eye has seen and no ear has heard, and what has not arisen in any
human heart, all that God has made ready for those who love him”[c]
10 for it is to us that God has revealed them[d] through the Spirit. The
Spirit searches out everything, even the depths of God. 11 For who
among human beings knows what is in a person except that person’s
own spirit within? In the same way no one comprehends what is in
God except the Spirit of God. 12 Now we have received not the spirit of
the world but the Spirit that comes from God, so that we may know
the things freely given us by God. 13 And we speak of these things in
words taught not by human wisdom but by the Spirit, interpreting
spiritual things to spiritual people.[e]

14 The unspiritual person[f] rejects what comes from God's Spirit, since
it seems absurd to him, and he is unable to grasp it, because it can
only be evaluated spiritually. 15 But the spiritual person discerns all
things, and is himself discerned by no one. 16 For "who has known
the mind of the Lord, so as to instruct him?"[g] But we have the mind
of Christ.

Notes

- a (2:1) Mystery: so the Westcott–Hort text with P46 (probably), Sinaiticus (original hand), Alexandrinus, and Ephraemi (as reported); many manuscripts read "testimony."
- b (2:4) Persuasive words of wisdom: the manuscripts differ widely here; many read "persuasive words of human wisdom," and P46 and a few others read "persuasion of wisdom" (as reported).
- c (2:9) Isa 64:4 (64:3 Hebrew), freely; compare Isa 52:15; 65:17.
- d (2:10) Revealed them: the sentence begun in v. 9 is incomplete in the Greek. "For" is the reading of the Westcott–Hort text, with P46 and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts read "but" ("But God has revealed them to us...").
- e (2:13) Interpreting spiritual things to spiritual people: or "combining spiritual things with spiritual words," or "comparing spiritual things with spiritual."
- f (2:14) The natural person: Greek *psychikos anthrōpos*, the person who lives on the merely natural level, without the Spirit.
- g (2:16) Isa 40:13, following the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.

Chapter 3

1 As for me, brothers, I was unable to talk to you as to people of the
Spirit; I had to talk to you as to people of flesh, as to babies in Christ.
2 Milk was what I gave you to drink, not solid food, for you were
not yet able to take it. Even now[a] you are still not able, 3 for you are
still fleshly. As long as there is jealousy and strife among you,[b] are
you not fleshly, behaving in merely human fashion? 4 When someone
declares, "I am for Paul," and someone else, "I am for Apollos," is that
not purely human?
5 Who is Apollos, then, and who is Paul? Just ministers by whose
means you came to faith, as the Lord assigned to each. 6 I planted;
Apollos watered; but it was God who kept making it grow. 7 So neither
the planter nor the waterer counts for anything, but only God, who
makes things grow. 8 The one who plants and the one who waters are

one, and each will receive his own wages in keeping with his own labor. 9 For we are God's fellow workers; you are God's field, God's building.
10 In keeping with the grace God gave me, I laid a foundation as an expert builder would, and another is now building upon it. Let every builder watch how he builds. 11 For no one can lay any other foundation than the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ. 12 Whether a person builds on the foundation in gold or silver or costly stones, in wood or grass or straw, 13 the quality of each builder's work will become plain; for the Day will expose it, since it is unveiled by fire, and fire will test the kind of work each has done. 14 If the work someone has built on it survives, he will receive a reward. 15 If the fire consumes someone's work, he will bear the loss; yet he will be saved himself, though as one escaping through flames.
16 Do you not know that you are God's temple[c] and that God's Spirit dwells in you? 17 If anyone ruins God's temple, God will ruin him. For the temple of God is holy, and that temple you are.
18 Do not fool yourselves. Anyone among you who imagines himself wise by the standards of this age must become foolish in order to become wise. 19 For the wisdom of this world is folly in God's sight. For it is written, "He catches the wise in their own craftiness,"[d] 20 and again, "The Lord knows the reasonings of the wise, that they are futile."[e] 21 So let no one boast in human beings. For everything belongs to you, 22 whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas or the world or life or death or the present or the future; all of it is yours, 23 and you are Christ's, and Christ is God's.

Notes

- a (3:2) Even now: "even" translates *eti*, bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- b (3:3) Among you: many later manuscripts add "and divisions."
- c (3:16) Temple: Greek *naos*, the sanctuary itself, where God dwells.
- d (3:19) Job 5:13.
- e (3:20) Ps 94:11 (93:11 Greek), following the Greek Old Testament, which reads "of human beings" where Paul has "of the wise." In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.

Chapter 4

1 This is how one should regard us: as assistants of Christ and stewards of God's mysteries. 2 Moreover, what is required of stewards is
that each be found trustworthy. 3 For my part, being put on trial by
you, or by any human court,[a] matters very little to me; I do not even
sit in judgment on myself. 4 For I am not aware of anything against
myself, but that does not acquit me. The one who examines me is
the Lord. 5 So do not pronounce judgment on anything before the
appointed time, before the Lord comes, who will both bring to light
what is hidden in darkness and lay bare the purposes of hearts. Then
each one will receive his praise from God.
6 Brothers, I have used myself and Apollos to illustrate these points for
your benefit, so that by our example you may learn the rule "Nothing
beyond what stands written," and none of you may swell with pride,
siding with one man against another. 7 Who sets you apart as special?
What do you possess that was not given to you? And if it was given,
why boast as if it were your own achievement? 8 Already you are
satisfied! Already you have become rich! You have begun to reign
without us! I only wish you did reign, so that we too might reign
with you. 9 I think God has exhibited us apostles at the tail end of
the procession, like men sentenced to death, for we have been made
a public show before the world, both angels and humans. 10 We are
fools on behalf of Christ, but you are wise in Christ. We are frail, but
you are strong. You are respected, but we are despised. 11 Right up to
this moment we are hungry and thirsty, wearing rags, beaten, and
homeless, 12 We wear ourselves out with the work of our own hands.
When we are reviled, we bless; when persecuted, we endure; 13 when
we are defamed, we respond gently. To this day we have become the
world's garbage, the refuse of all things.
14 I am not writing these things to shame you, but to admonish you as
my dear children. 15 For though you may have countless guardians[b]
in Christ, you do not have many fathers. For in Christ Jesus I became
your father through the gospel. 16 I urge you, then, be imitators of
me. 17 For this reason I am sending Timothy to you,[c] my dear and
trustworthy child in the Lord, who will bring to your mind how I live

in Christ Jesus,[d] as I teach everywhere in every congregation. 18 Some have become puffed up, as though I were not coming to you. 19 But I will come to you soon, if the Lord wills, and then I will find out not the talk of these puffed-up people but their power. 20 God's kingdom is a matter not of words but of power. 21 Which will it be? Should I visit you with a stick, or with love and a gentle spirit?

Notes

- a (4:3) Human court: literally "human day," in contrast with the Day of the Lord.
- b (4:15) Guardians: Greek *paidagōgos*, the household slave who supervised a child's conduct and escorted him to school (compare Gal 3:24).
- c (4:17) Timothy: Greek, "one who honors God."
- d (4:17) Jesus: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.

Chapter 5

1 There is a widespread report of sexual immorality among you, of a sort not even tolerated among the nations: a man has taken his father's wife.[a] 2 And you are puffed up! Should you not instead have gone into mourning, so that the man who did this would be removed from your company? 3 As for me, although I am away in body, I am here in spirit, and I have already, as though present, pronounced judgment on the man who did this. 4 When you meet in the name of [our] Lord Jesus, with my spirit joining you and the power of our Lord Jesus behind you, 5 deliver such a man to Satan, for the ruin of his flesh, with a view to the rescue of his spirit on the Lord's day.[b]
6 Your boasting is no good thing. Are you unaware that a little yeast leavens the whole lump of dough? 7 Clean out the old yeast, so that you may be a fresh batch, as in fact you are unleavened. For our Passover lamb, Christ, has been sacrificed.[c] 8 So let us keep the festival not with old yeast, the yeast of vice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.
9 In my letter[d] I wrote to you not to mix with sexually immoral people, 10 not meaning the immoral people of this world in general, or the greedy and swindlers, or idolaters; for then you would have to leave the world altogether. 11 What I am now writing to you is that you must not keep company with anyone who bears the name of brother if he is sexually immoral or greedy, an idolater, a slanderer, a drunkard, or

a swindler; with such a person do not even share a meal. 12 For what
business is it of mine to judge outsiders? Is it not those inside whom
you are to judge? 13 Those outside, God judges. “Drive out the wicked
person from among you.”[e]

Notes

- a (5:1) Father’s wife: evidently his stepmother. Compare Lev 18:8.
- b (5:5) The Lord’s day: that is, the day of the Lord’s coming. Many manuscripts add “Jesus,” and some “our Lord Jesus Christ.”
- c (5:7) Sacrificed: many later manuscripts add “for us.”
- d (5:9) My letter: an earlier letter of Paul to Corinth that has not survived.
- e (5:13) Deut 17:7 and similar passages (Deut 19:19; 22:21, 24; 24:7).

Chapter 6

1 When one of you has a grievance against another, how dare he go
to law before the unrighteous instead of before the saints? 2 Or are
you unaware that the saints will judge the world? And if the world
is to be judged by you, are you unfit to try the most trivial cases? 3
Are you not aware that angels will come under our judgment? Then
surely the affairs of this life will! 4 So if you have such everyday cases,
do you seat as judges those who carry no standing in the church? 5
I say this to put you to shame. Is there really not one wise person
among you who will be able to settle a dispute between one brother
and another? 6 Yet here is a brother suing a brother, and in front of
unbelievers at that! 7 In fact, to have lawsuits with one another at all
already means a defeat for you. Why not rather put up with wrong?
Why not rather let yourselves be cheated? 8 Instead you yourselves
do wrong and cheat, and you do it to brothers!
9 Or are you unaware that the unrighteous will not inherit God’s
kingdom? Do not be led astray: neither the sexually immoral, nor
idolaters, nor adulterers, nor *malakoi* nor *arsenokoitai*,[a] 10 nor
those who steal or grasp for more, nor those given to drink, abusive
speech, or extortion, will have any share in God’s kingdom. 11 And
this is what some of you were. But you were washed clean, you were
made holy, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ[b]
and by the Spirit of our God.

12 “I am free to do anything,”[c] you say; but not everything does any
good. “I am free to do anything”; but I will not let anything master
me. 13 “Meals for the belly, and the belly for meals,” and God will bring
both to nothing. But the body exists not for immorality but for the
Lord, and the Lord for the body. 14 And God raised the Lord and will
also raise us up by his power. 15 Do you not know that your bodies
are members of Christ? Shall I then take the members of Christ and
make them members of a prostitute? Never! 16 Or are you not aware
that whoever unites with a prostitute is one body with her? For it
says, “The two will be one flesh.”[d] 17 Whoever is joined to the Lord,
however, is one spirit with him. 18 Run from sexual immorality. Every
other sin people commit is outside the body, but whoever commits
sexual immorality sins against his own body. 19 Or do you not realize
that your body is a sanctuary of the Holy Spirit who lives in you,
whom you received from God? You do not belong to yourselves, 20 for
a price was paid for you. Honor God, then, with your body.[e]

Notes

- a (6:9) *Malakoi* … *arsenokoitai*: two Greek terms left untranslated here because their exact sense is disputed. *Malakoi* means literally “soft ones” and in this context is usually taken to refer to the passive partner in male homosexual acts; *arsenokoitai* (“men who lie with males”), apparently drawn from the Greek of Lev 18:22 and 20:13, is usually taken to refer to the active partner, though some interpreters limit both terms to exploitative practices such as pederasty or prostitution.
- b (6:11) The Lord Jesus Christ: “our” is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text after “the Lord.”
- c (6:12) I am free to do anything: the quotation marks here and in v. 13 reflect the common view that Paul is citing slogans used at Corinth.
- d (6:16) Gen 2:24.
- e (6:20) Body: many later manuscripts add “and in your spirit, which are God’s.”

Chapter 7

1 Now, regarding what you wrote about: “It is good for a man to have
no sexual contact with a woman.”[a] 2 But because of the cases of sexual
immorality, let each man have his own wife and each woman her
own husband. 3 Let the husband give his wife what is due to her, and
likewise the wife to her husband. 4 The wife has no exclusive right

over her own body, but the husband has; likewise the husband has no exclusive right over his own body, but the wife has. 5 Stop refusing each other, unless it is by consent and for a limited time, to have leisure for prayer,[b] and afterward resume your relations, so that Satan does not tempt you because you lack self-control. 6 I say this, though, as a concession, not as a command. 7 My wish is that all people were like me; but each has his particular gift from God, this one in one way and that one in another.

8 My advice to those without spouses and to widows is that they do well to stay single as I do. 9 But if they are not exercising self-control, let them marry; for it is better to marry than to burn with desire.

10 To the married I give this instruction, which comes from the Lord, not from me: a wife should not part from her husband 11 (and if she has separated, she should either stay unmarried or make peace with her husband), and the husband is not to send his wife away.

12 To everyone else I speak for myself, not for the Lord. Suppose a brother has an unbelieving wife who agrees to go on living with him: he should not send her away. 13 And suppose a woman has an unbelieving husband who agrees to go on living with her: she should not send him away. 14 For the unbelieving husband has been made holy through his wife, and the unbelieving wife has been made holy through the brother.[c] Otherwise your children would be unclean, but as it is they are holy. 15 But if the unbelieving partner separates, let the separation take place. In such circumstances the brother or the sister is not bound. God has called you[d] to live in peace. 16 For how do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband? Or how do you know, husband, whether you will save your wife?

17 Nevertheless, each person should live in the situation the Lord has given them, the situation in which God called them. This is my instruction in all the congregations. 18 Was someone already circumcised when he was called? Let him not try to undo his circumcision. Has someone been called while uncircumcised? Let him not be circumcised. 19 Circumcision counts for nothing and uncircumcision counts for nothing; what counts is keeping God's commandments. 20 Each one should stay in the condition in which he was called. 21 Were

you a slave when called? Do not let it trouble you. But if you are actually able to become free, make use of the opportunity instead.[e]
22 For a slave who was called in the Lord is the Lord's freed person;
in the same way, a free person who was called is Christ's slave. 23 A
price was paid for you; do not turn yourselves into slaves of men. 24
Each one, brothers, in whatever condition he was called, in that let
him remain before God.
25 About virgins I have received no instruction from the Lord, but I
offer my view as someone the Lord in his mercy has made reliable.
26 My view, then, in light of the present crisis, is that a person does
well to stay just as he is. 27 Tied to a wife? Do not look for a release.
Released from a wife? Do not look for a wife. 28 But if you do marry,
you have not sinned, and if a virgin marries, she has not sinned. Yet
those who marry will have trouble in the flesh, and I would spare
you that.
29 What I mean, brothers, is this: the time has been cut short. From now
on let those who have wives be as though they had none, 30 those who
cry should live as if they were not crying, those who are happy as if
they were not happy, those who purchase as if they owned nothing,
31 and those who make use of the world as though not making full use
of it. For the present shape of this world is passing away.
32 I want you to be free of worry. An unmarried man cares about the
Lord's work, about how he can please the Lord. 33 whereas the married
man has the world's affairs on his mind and how he may please his
wife, 34 and he is divided. And the unmarried woman and the virgin
are concerned about the Lord's affairs, so as to be holy in both body
and spirit; but the married woman is concerned about the affairs of
the world, how to please her husband.[f] 35 I am saying this for your
own benefit, not to throw a noose around you, but to promote what
is fitting and to secure undistracted devotion to the Lord.
36 If anyone believes he is acting dishonorably toward his fiancée,[g]
if she is getting on in years and there is need, he may do what he
likes; he does not sin. They should marry. 37 But the man who is
firmly settled in his mind, who is under no pressure and has authority
over his own choice, and has decided in his heart to keep his fiancée

unmarried, does well. 38 So then the one who marries his virgin does well, and the one who does not marry will do better.
39 A wife is bound for as long as her husband lives. But if her husband dies,[h] she is free to be married to whom she wishes, only in the Lord.
40 But she is more blessed, as I see it, if she stays as she is; and I believe I also have God's Spirit.

Notes

- a (7:1) It is good…: most interpreters take this as a quotation from the Corinthians' letter, which Paul then qualifies.
- b (7:5) Prayer: many later manuscripts read "to fasting and prayer."
- c (7:14) Through the brother: that is, through the believing husband. Many later manuscripts read "through her husband."
- d (7:15) Called you: many manuscripts read "called us."
- e (7:21) Make use of the opportunity instead: or "rather make use of your present condition." The Greek says only "rather use," and interpreters divide over whether the object is freedom or slavery.
- f (7:34) And he is divided…: the text and punctuation of vv. 33–34 vary among manuscripts. The translation follows the Westcott–Hort text; other manuscripts read "and the wife and the virgin are divided: the unmarried woman is concerned…"
- g (7:36) His virgin: probably his fiancée, though some take it as a father and his virgin daughter (so that "marries" in v. 38 would mean "gives in marriage"), or as a couple living in spiritual marriage.
- h (7:39) Dies: literally "falls asleep."

Chapter 8

1 Now concerning meat offered to idols: we realize that "we all have knowledge."[a] Knowledge puffs up, but love strengthens. 2 If anyone imagines he has come to know something, he has not yet come to know it as he ought. 3 But if anyone loves God, that person is known by him.
4 So then, regarding the eating of food sacrificed to idols, we know that "an idol is nothing at all in the world" and that "there is no God but one." 5 Granted, there may be beings called gods in heaven or on earth (and indeed there are plenty of "gods" and plenty of "lords"), 6 yet for us there is a single God, the Father, source of everything and the goal of our lives, and a single Lord, Jesus Christ, by whom everything exists and by whom we live.[b]

7 Not everyone, however, has this knowledge. Some, through being
accustomed to the idol until now, eat the food as something actually
sacrificed to an idol, and their conscience, being weak, is defiled. 8
Food will not commend us to God. We lose nothing by not eating, and
gain nothing by eating.[c] 9 Only watch out that this liberty of yours
does not trip up those who are weak. 10 For if someone sees you, who
have knowledge, reclining at table in an idol's temple, will not his
conscience, weak as he is, be emboldened to eat food sacrificed to
idols? 11 And so the weak one, the brother for whom Christ died, is
destroyed by your knowledge. 12 When you sin in this way against the
brothers and wound their weak conscience, you sin against Christ. 13
Therefore, if what I eat causes my brother to fall, I will never again
eat meat, so as not to cause my brother to fall.

Notes

- a (8:1) All of us possess knowledge: probably a Corinthian slogan, as also the phrases quoted in v. 4.
- b (8:6) Through whom we exist: compare Deut 6:4, where "one Lord" stands for Yahweh; Paul here divides the confession between the Father and Jesus.
- c (8:8) The order of the two clauses in this verse is reversed in many manuscripts.

Chapter 9

1 Am I not free? Am I not an apostle?[a] Have I not seen Jesus our Lord?
Are you not my work in the Lord? 2 If to others I am no apostle, at
least to you I am, for you are the seal that certifies my apostleship in
the Lord.

3 This is my defense to those who would put me on trial. 4 Have we
no right to eat and drink? 5 Have we no right to take along a sister as
wife, as the other apostles do, and the Lord's brothers, and Cephas? 6
Or are Barnabas[b] and I the only ones obliged to earn our own keep?
7 What soldier ever pays his own wages? What man plants vines and
never tastes the grapes? What shepherd gets no milk from his flock?
8 Is this mere human reasoning? Does the Law not say it too? 9 For
Moses' law says, "Do not muzzle an ox as it threshes grain."[c] Is God
worried about oxen? 10 Or does he really speak entirely for us? Yes,
it was written for us, because the plowman should plow with hope,
and the one threshing should do so expecting a portion. 11 Since we

have sown in you the things of the Spirit, is it so great a thing for us to harvest your material goods? 12 If others share this right over you, do not we have a stronger claim? Yet we have not made use of this right; instead we bear with everything rather than put any obstacle in the way of the gospel of Christ. 13 Do you not realize that those who work in the temple are fed from the temple, and those who attend the altar receive a portion of the altar's offerings? 14 Likewise the Lord ordered that those who announce the gospel should be supported by the gospel.

15 But I have made use of none of these rights. And I am not writing this so that it may be done in my case. I would sooner die than have anyone make my boast an empty one. 16 Preaching the gospel is nothing for me to boast of, for I am under compulsion. How wretched I would be if I failed to preach it! 17 If I do it willingly, I earn wages; but if I do it unwillingly, I am still entrusted with a task. 18 So what is my pay? Just this: to make the gospel available without cost when I preach, and so not to press my rights in the gospel to the full.

19 Free as I am from everyone, I have enslaved myself to everyone, in order to gain all the more of them. 20 With Jews I lived as a Jew in order to gain Jews; with those under the Law, as someone under the Law, though I myself am not under the Law,[d] in order to gain those under the Law. 21 With those without the Law, I lived as one without the Law (not that I am free from God's law; I am bound by Christ's law), in order to gain those without the Law. 22 To the weak I became weak, to win the weak. I have become all things to all people, so that by all means I may save some. 23 I do it all for the sake of the gospel, that I may have a share in it.

24 In a race, as you know, all the runners compete, yet a single one carries off the prize. Run so as to carry it off. 25 Every competitor practices discipline in everything. They do so for a perishable crown, but we for an imperishable one. 26 That is why I do not run without a finish line in view, and I do not throw punches at empty air. 27 Instead I pummel my body and make it my slave, for fear that after preaching to others I myself might be disqualified.

Notes

- a (9:1) Am I not free? Am I not an apostle?: many later manuscripts reverse the order of these two questions.
- b (9:6) Barnabas: explained in Acts 4:36 as "son of encouragement."
- c (9:9) Deut 25:4.
- d (9:20) Though I myself am not under the Law: absent from many later manuscripts.

Chapter 10

1 I want you to understand, brothers, that our forefathers were every
one of them beneath the cloud, and every one of them went through
the sea, 2 and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea,
3 and all ate the same spiritual food, 4 and all drank the same spiritual
drink; for they drank from a spiritual rock that went along with them,
and the rock was Christ. 5 Yet with most of them God was not pleased,
for they were struck down in the wilderness.[a]
6 These events serve as patterns for us, warning us not to set our
hearts on evil as they did. 7 Do not become idolaters, as some of them
were; as it is written, "The people sat down to eat and drink, and
rose up to play."[b] 8 Nor should we commit sexual sin, as some of them
did, so that twenty-three thousand died in one day.[c] 9 Nor should we
try the Lord's[d] patience, as some of them did, and the serpents killed
them. 10 Nor should we murmur, as some of them murmured and
perished at the hand of the Destroyer. 11 Now these things happened
to them by way of example, and they were written down as a warning
for us, on whom the ends of the ages have come. 12 So let anyone
who thinks he is standing take care that he does not fall. 13 Every trial
that has come upon you is the ordinary human lot. And God can be
trusted: he will not allow you to be tried past what you can endure.
Along with the trial he will make an exit as well, so that you are able
to withstand it.
14 Therefore, my dear friends, flee from idolatry. 15 I am addressing
people of good sense; weigh what I say for yourselves. 16 The cup
of blessing over which we say the blessing: is it not participation in
Christ's blood? The bread we break: is it not participation in Christ's
body? 17 Because there is one loaf, we who are many are one body, for
we all partake of the one loaf. 18 Look at the people of Israel by physical

descent: do those who eat the sacrifices not share in the altar? 19 So
what do I mean? That meat offered to idols counts for something, or
that an idol is something? 20 No, but that what they[e] sacrifice, they
sacrifice to demons and not to God.[f] I do not want you to become
partners with demons. 21 You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the
cup of demons. You cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the
table of demons. 22 Or are we trying to provoke the Lord to jealousy?
[g] Are we stronger than he is?
23 "Anything is allowed," but not everything helps. "Anything is
allowed," but not everything builds up. 24 No one should look out
for himself; let him look out for his neighbor. 25 Anything on sale
in the market you may eat, without asking questions on grounds
of conscience, 26 for "the earth is the Lord's, and everything in it."[h]
27 If one of the unbelievers invites you to dinner and you want to
go, eat whatever is set before you without raising any question for
conscience' sake. 28 But should anyone tell you, "This meat came from
a sacrifice," then abstain from it, out of regard for the person who
pointed it out, and for conscience' sake.[i] 29 I mean the other person's
conscience, not yours. For why should another's conscience pass
verdict on my freedom? 30 If I partake with thanksgiving, why am I
denounced because of something I give thanks for?
31 Whatever you are doing, then, eating or drinking or anything else,
do it all to bring glory to God. 32 Give no offense to Jews or to Greeks or
to the church of God, 33 just as I try to please everyone in everything,
not seeking my own advantage but that of the many, so that they may
be saved.

Notes

- a (10:5) Struck down in the wilderness: see Num 14:16, 29–30.
- b (10:7) Exod 32:6.
- c (10:8) Twenty-three thousand: Num 25:9 gives twenty-four thousand.
- d (10:9) The Lord's: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus and Sinaiticus (as reported); P46 and many other manuscripts read "Christ," and a few "God." See Num 21:5–6.
- e (10:20) They: "the nations" (that is, the pagans) is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- f (10:20) To demons and not to God: echoing Deut 32:17.

- g (10:22) Provoke the Lord to jealousy: echoing Deut 32:21, where the Lord is Yahweh.
- h (10:26) Ps 24:1. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- i (10:28) Conscience' sake: many later manuscripts add "for the earth is the Lord's, and everything in it" (compare v. 26).

Chapter 11

1 Take me as your model, just as I take Christ as mine.
2 I commend you for keeping me in mind in everything and for
holding fast to the traditions just as I passed them on to you. 3 Yet
I would have you understand that Christ is every man's head,[a] a
husband is his wife's head, and God is Christ's head. 4 Any man who
prays or prophesies with something hanging down over his head
brings shame on his head. 5 And any woman who prays or prophesies
with her head uncovered brings shame on her head, for it is just the
same as if her head were shaved. 6 For if a woman will not cover
herself, she might as well cut her hair short; but if it is shameful for a
woman to have her hair cut short or shaved, let her cover herself. 7 A
man ought not to cover his head, since he is the image and glory of
God; but the woman is the glory of the man. 8 Man was not taken out
of woman; woman was taken out of man. 9 Nor was man made for
woman's sake; woman was made for man's. 10 That is why the woman
ought to have authority over her head,[b] because of the angels. 11 In
the Lord, though, neither is woman anything apart from man, nor
man apart from woman. 12 For as woman came from man, so too man
comes into being through woman; and all things come from God. 13
Decide among yourselves: is it fitting for a woman to pray to God
uncovered? 14 Does nature itself not teach you that long hair on a man
is dishonorable to him, 15 but if a woman wears her hair long it is
her glory? For her long hair has been given to her as a covering. 16 If
anyone is inclined to be contentious about this, we recognize no such
custom,[c] nor do the churches of God.
17 In giving the following instructions I do not commend you, because
your meetings do more harm than good. 18 First of all, I hear that there
are rifts among you when you meet as a congregation, and I partly
believe it. 19 For there must indeed be factions among you, so that the

genuine among you may stand out. 20 So when you meet together, it is
not really the Lord's supper that you eat. 21 For as you eat, each of you
goes ahead with his own supper, and one stays hungry while another
gets drunk. 22 Really! Do you lack homes where you can eat and drink?
Or do you hold God's church in contempt and put to shame those
who are poor? What shall I tell you? Should I praise you? On this
point, no praise from me!
23 What I passed on to you I myself received from the Lord: on the
night of his betrayal the Lord Jesus took a loaf, 24 and after giving
thanks he broke it and said, "This is my body, which is for you.[d] Do
this to remember me." 25 In the same way he took the cup after dinner,
saying, "This cup is the new covenant sealed by my blood. As often
as you drink it, do so in memory of me." 26 For as often as you eat
this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he
comes.
27 Anyone, then, who eats the bread or drinks the Lord's cup
unworthily will be held guilty of sinning against the Lord's body and
blood. 28 Let a person test himself, then, and only so eat of the bread
and drink of the cup. 29 Whoever eats and drinks[e] without recognizing
the body brings judgment on himself by his eating and drinking. 30
That is why many among you are weak and sick, and a number have
died.[f] 31 If we would examine ourselves properly, we would escape
judgment. 32 When we are judged by the Lord, however, we are being
disciplined, so that we may not be condemned along with the world.
33 So then, my brothers, when you gather to eat, wait for one another.
34 If anyone is hungry, let him eat at home, so that your gatherings do
not lead to judgment. The remaining matters I will set in order when
I come.

Notes

- a (11:3) Head: Greek *kephalē*. "Man" and "woman" may also be rendered "husband" and "wife" throughout this passage. Whether the word here implies authority, source, or prominence is debated.
- b (11:10) Authority over her head: or "a sign of authority on her head"; the Greek is simply "authority on (or over) her head." Some early Latin and Greek witnesses (as reported) read "a veil."

- c (11:16) No such custom: that is, no custom of contentiousness, or of praying uncovered.
- d (11:24) For you: many later manuscripts read “broken for you,” and some “given for you” (compare Luke 22:19).
- e (11:29) Eats and drinks: many later manuscripts add “unworthily” and, after “body,” add “of the Lord.”
- f (11:30) Died: literally “are sleeping.”

Chapter 12

1 On the subject of spiritual gifts,[a] brothers, I would not have you left
in ignorance. 2 You know that when you were pagans you were drawn
away, however you were led, to idols that cannot speak. 3 Understand,
then, that nobody who speaks by God’s Spirit ever says, “A curse on
Jesus!” and nobody can say, “Jesus is Lord!” except by the Holy Spirit.
4 There are distributions of gifts, but the same Spirit; 5 distributions of
service, and the same Lord; 6 distributions of activity, and the same
God, who brings about all of them in everyone. 7 To each one the Spirit
is made manifest for the common good. 8 To one is given through the
Spirit a word of wisdom, to another a word of knowledge according
to the same Spirit, 9 to another faith by the same Spirit, to another
gifts of healing by the one Spirit, 10 to another the working of miracles,
to another prophecy, to another the ability to distinguish spirits, to
another various kinds of tongues, and to another the interpretation
of tongues. 11 All these are the work of one and the same Spirit, who
apportions to each individually just as he wills.
12 For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the
members of the body, many as they are, make up one body, so it is
with Christ. 13 In one Spirit we were all baptized into one body, Jews
and Greeks, slaves and free alike, and of one Spirit we were all given
to drink.
14 For indeed the body is not one member but many. 15 If the foot should
say, “Because I am not a hand, I am no part of the body,” it would not
for that reason cease to belong to the body. 16 And if the ear should
say, “Because I am not an eye, I am no part of the body,” it would
not for that reason cease to belong to the body. 17 If the whole body
were an eye, where would hearing be? If the whole were hearing,

where would the sense of smell be? 18 But as it is, God has arranged
the members, each one of them, in the body as he chose. 19 Were they
all one single member, what would become of the body? 20 In reality
there are numerous members but a single body. 21 The eye cannot
tell the hand, "I do not need you," nor can the head tell the feet, "I
do not need you." 22 Quite the reverse: the members of the body that
appear feebler are the ones we cannot do without, 23 and those parts of
the body we think less honorable we clothe with greater honor, and
our unpresentable parts are treated with greater modesty, 24 which
the more presentable parts have no need of. God has put the body
together so as to give more honor to the part that was lacking it, 25
so that there may be no division in the body, but that the members
may have the same concern for one another. 26 When one part hurts,
every part hurts along with it; when one part is honored, every part
celebrates along with it.
27 Now you are Christ's body, and individually members of it. 28 And
God has placed in the church first apostles, second prophets, third
teachers, then miracles, then gifts of healing, helping, guiding, and
various kinds of tongues. 29 Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all
teachers? Do all work miracles? 30 Do all possess healing gifts? Do all
speak with tongues? Do all give interpretations? 31 Set your hearts on
the greater gifts.[b] And now I will point you to a way that surpasses
them all.

Notes

- a (12:1) Spiritual gifts: or "spiritual people"; the Greek *pneumatikōn* can be masculine or neuter.
- b (12:31) Set your hearts on the greater gifts: or, as a statement, "You set your hearts for the greater gifts." Many later manuscripts read "the better gifts."

Chapter 13

1 Though I speak with human tongues and angelic tongues, if I lack
love I am a noisy gong or a clashing cymbal. 2 Even if I have the gift
of prophecy, and grasp every mystery and every kind of knowledge,
and have complete faith that can relocate mountains, but lack love, I
am nothing. 3 Though I hand out all my possessions in food for others,

and though I give up my body so that I may boast,[a] if I lack love it profits me nothing.
4 Love is patient; love is kind; love is not jealous; love does not brag, is not puffed up, 5 does not behave shamefully, does not seek its own interests, is not easily angered, does not keep account of wrongs, 6 takes no delight in injustice but rejoices with the truth; 7 it bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.
8 Love never fails. As for prophecies, they will be done away with; as for tongues, they will cease; as for knowledge, it will be done away with. 9 For we know in part, and we prophesy in part; 10 but when what is complete comes, what is partial will be done away with. 11 In my childhood my speech, my thinking, and my reasoning were a child's; now that I am grown, I have laid aside childish ways. 12 For the present we see as by reflection in a mirror, indistinctly,[b] but then we shall see face to face. For the present my knowledge is partial; then I shall know as completely as I have been known. 13 So now faith, hope, and love remain, these three; but the greatest of these is love.

Notes

- a (13:3) So that I may boast: Greek *hina kauchēsōmai*, the reading of the Westcott–Hort text, supported by P46, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and Vaticanus (as reported). Many other manuscripts and early translations read *hina kauthēsomai* (or *kauthēsōmai*), "to be burned," a difference of a single letter in Greek. "So that I may boast" is generally taken to mean boasting in self-sacrifice (compare 9:15–16; 2 Cor 11:30), or possibly selling oneself into slavery; "to be burned" would refer to martyrdom, or to branding as a slave.
- b (13:12) Indistinctly: literally "in a riddle." Ancient mirrors were of polished metal.

Chapter 14

1 Make love your aim, and be eager for spiritual gifts, especially that you may prophesy. 2 For whoever talks in a tongue talks not to people but to God; nobody understands, since he speaks mysteries by the Spirit. 3 The one who prophesies, by contrast, speaks to people for their upbuilding, encouragement, and comfort. 4 Tongue-speaking edifies the speaker; prophesying edifies the church. 5 I would be glad if every one of you spoke in tongues, but gladder still if you prophesied.

Prophesying ranks above speaking in tongues, unless the tongue is interpreted so that the church gains from it.

6 Suppose, brothers, I came to you speaking in tongues: what use
would I be to you, if I brought you no revelation, no knowledge, no
prophecy, no teaching? 7 Think of lifeless things that make a sound,
a pipe or a lyre: unless the notes are distinct, how can anyone tell
the tune on pipe or lyre? 8 And if the trumpet gives an uncertain call,
who will get ready for battle? 9 You are in the same position: if the
speech your tongue produces is not clear, how can anyone follow
what you say? Your words will be lost on the wind. 10 There are, it
may be, ever so many kinds of languages in the world, and none is
without meaning. 11 So if I do not grasp what the sounds mean, the
speaker and I will be strangers babbling to each other.[a] 12 So it is with
you: since you are eager for spirits,[b] strive to excel in building up
the church.

13 That is why someone who speaks in a tongue ought to pray to be
able to interpret it. 14 For[c] if I pray in a tongue, my spirit prays, but my
mind is unproductive. 15 What then? I will pray with the spirit, and
I will pray with the mind as well; I will sing praise with the spirit,
and I will sing praise with the mind as well. 16 Else, when you bless
God in the spirit, how is the uninstructed person[d] sitting among you
to add his "Amen" to your thanksgiving? He has no idea what you
are saying. 17 Your thanksgiving may be fine, but it does nothing to
build up your neighbor. 18 Thank God, I speak with tongues more than
any of you. 19 yet in the assembly I prefer to say five words with my
understanding, to teach others too, rather than countless words in
a tongue.

20 Brothers, stop thinking like children. Be babies when it comes
to malice, but adults in your thinking. 21 The Law has it written:
"Through men of other tongues and through foreign lips I will speak
to this people, and not even so will they hear me, says the Lord."[e] 22
Tongues, then, serve as a sign for unbelievers, not believers; prophecy
serves as a sign for believers, not unbelievers. 23 So if the entire
congregation gathers and everyone speaks in tongues, and visitors or
unbelievers enter, will they not conclude that you are mad? 24 But if

everyone prophesies and an unbeliever or visitor enters, he is exposed
by everything said and examined by everyone; 25 his heart's hidden
things are revealed, and he will fall on his face and worship God,
announcing, "God truly is among you!"[f]
26 What should we conclude, brothers and sisters? When you assem-
ble, each person contributes a psalm, a lesson, a revelation, a tongue,
or an interpretation. All of it must serve to build up the community.
27 As for tongue-speaking, let two speak, or three at the most, taking
turns, and have someone interpret. 28 But if there is no interpreter,
let him keep silent in the church and speak to himself and to God.
29 Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh what is
said. 30 If a revelation comes to another person sitting there, let the
first one be silent. 31 All of you are able to prophesy in succession, so
that everyone may be taught and everyone encouraged. 32 Prophets'
spirits are under the control of the prophets. 33 For God is the God not
of confusion but of peace, as in all the churches of the saints.[g]
34 Let the women keep silence in the assemblies,[h] for it is not granted
them to speak; let them rather be subordinate, as the Law also says. 35
If they want to learn something, let them ask their own husbands at
home. For it is shameful for a woman to speak in church. 36 Was it from
you that God's word went out? Or has it come to you and nobody
else? 37 Anyone who considers himself a prophet or a spiritual person
must recognize that the things I write to you are the Lord's command.[i]
38 If anyone disregards this, he is disregarded.[j] 39 In short, my brothers,
set your hearts on prophesying, and do not prevent anyone from
speaking in tongues. 40 But let everything be done decently and in
order.

Notes

- a (14:11) Strangers babbling to each other: literally "I will be a barbarian to the speaker, and the speaker a barbarian to me." Greek *barbaros*, "foreigner," is one whose speech sounds like babbling.
- b (14:12) Spirits: that is, manifestations of the Spirit.
- c (14:14) For: bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- d (14:16) The uninstructed person: Greek *idiōtēs*, a non-specialist; perhaps an enquirer or an uninstructed believer.

- e (14:21) Isa 28:11–12, in a form that differs from both the Hebrew and the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh. "The Law" here refers to Scripture generally.
- f (14:25) Compare Isa 45:14; Zech 8:23.
- g (14:33) As in all the churches of the saints: the punctuation is disputed. These words may instead begin v. 34 ("As in all the churches of the saints, let the women keep silent…").
- h (14:34) Let the women keep silence in the assemblies: vv. 34–35 stand here in all known Greek manuscripts and in the Westcott–Hort text, but in a group of Western witnesses (Codex Claromontanus [D], Codex Augiensis [F], Codex Boernerianus [G], some Old Latin manuscripts, and the Latin writer Ambrosiaster, as reported) they are placed after v. 40. Some scholars infer from this, and from scribal sigla reported in Codex Vaticanus and Codex Fuldensis, that the verses began as a marginal gloss that was later copied into the text at two different points; others hold that they are Paul's and that the Western order is a scribal relocation intended to keep the discussion of prophecy together. How the instruction relates to 11:5, where women pray and prophesy, is also debated. The traditional verse order is kept here.
- i (14:37) The Lord's command: many manuscripts read "the Lord's commands," and some omit "command."
- j (14:38) He is disregarded: that is, he is not recognized (by God). So the Westcott–Hort text with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus (as reported); P46, Vaticanus and many later manuscripts read "let him be ignorant."

Chapter 15

1 Now, brothers, I am reminding you of the gospel I proclaimed to you,
which you also accepted, on which you have taken your stand, 2 and
through which you are being saved, if you hold firmly to the message
as I preached it to you; unless your believing was to no purpose. 3
For among the first things I handed on to you was what I in turn had
received: that Christ died for our sins in keeping with the Scriptures,
4 that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in keeping
with the Scriptures, 5 He appeared to Cephas, and after that to the
Twelve. 6 After that he appeared to upward of five hundred brothers
at one time, most of whom are alive to this day, though some have
fallen asleep. 7 After that he appeared to James,[a] then to the apostles
as a body. 8 And last of all he appeared to me also, as though to one
born out of due time.[b] 9 For I am the smallest of the apostles, unfit
even to be called an apostle, because I harassed God's church. 10 But

by God's grace I am what I am, and his grace toward me did not prove
fruitless. On the contrary, I toiled harder than all of them, though it
was not I but the grace of God that was with me. 11 So whether it was
I or they, this is how we preach, and this is how you came to believe.
12 Now if the message is that Christ was raised from the dead, how
do some among you claim there is no resurrection of the dead? 13 If
there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ has not been raised
either; 14 and if Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is empty
and your faith is empty as well. 15 Moreover, we turn out to be lying
witnesses about God, since we testified that God raised Christ, whom
he did not raise, supposing the dead are never raised. 16 For if the dead
are not raised, neither has Christ been raised; 17 and if Christ has not
been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins. 18 It would
follow that those who have died in Christ[c] are lost. 19 If for this life
only we have set our hope on Christ, of all people we are the most to
be pitied.
20 But as things are, Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits
of those who have fallen asleep. 21 For since death came through a
man, through a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. 22 For
as in Adam[d] all die, so too in Christ will all be made alive. 23 Each,
however, in proper sequence: first Christ, the firstfruits; afterward, at
his coming, Christ's own people. 24 Then the end will come, when he
delivers the kingdom to his God and Father, once he has put down
all rule and all authority and power. 25 For he must reign until he has
put all his enemies under his feet.[e] 26 The last enemy to be abolished
is death. 27 For "he has put all things in subjection under his feet."[f]
But when it says "all things" are subjected, it is evident that he who
subjected all things to him is excepted. 28 Once everything has been
placed under him, then the Son himself will also come under the one
who placed everything under him, so that God will be everything to
everyone.
29 Otherwise, what will those people accomplish who are baptized on
behalf of the dead?[g] If the dead are not raised at all, why are people
baptized on their behalf? 30 And why are we ourselves in danger every
hour? 31 I die every day! That is as sure, brothers, as my pride in you,

which I have in Christ Jesus our Lord. 32 If with merely human hopes
I fought with wild beasts at Ephesus,[h] what have I gained? If the dead
are not raised, "Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die."[i] 33 Make no
mistake: "Evil associations spoil good morals."[j] 34 Sober up, as is right,
and stop sinning; for some have no knowledge of God. I say this to
your shame.
35 But someone will ask, "How are the dead raised? With what kind
of body do they come?" 36 You fool! The seed you sow is not brought
to life unless it first dies. 37 And the thing you sow is not the body
that is to come into being but a bare seed, of wheat, say, or of some
other grain. 38 Then God clothes it with a body of his own choosing,
giving each seed its proper body. 39 Flesh is not all alike: human flesh
is one sort, and animal flesh another; birds have another, and fish
another. 40 Bodies exist in heaven and bodies on earth, but the glory
of those in heaven differs from the glory of those on earth. 41 The sun
has one kind of brightness, the moon another, and the stars another;
indeed, one star outshines another. 42 So it is with the resurrection of
the dead. What is sown perishable is raised imperishable. 43 It is sown
in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in
power. 44 It is sown a natural[k] body; it is raised a spiritual body. If there
is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body. 45 So also it is written,
"The first man, Adam, became a living being";[l] the last Adam became
a life-giving spirit. 46 Yet the spiritual does not come first; the natural
comes first, and afterward the spiritual. 47 The first man came out of
the earth, a man of dust; the second man comes out of heaven.[m] 48 The
earthly are like the earthly man; the heavenly are like the heavenly
man. 49 And just as we have borne the likeness of the man of dust, let
us also bear[n] the likeness of the man of heaven.
50 What I am saying, brothers, is that flesh and blood can have no
share in God's kingdom, and decay can have no share in what does
not decay. 51 Listen, I tell you a mystery: we shall not all fall asleep,
but we shall all be changed,[o] 52 in a moment, in the blink of an eye,
at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be
raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. 53 For this perishable
body must clothe itself with the imperishable, and this mortal body

must clothe itself with immortality. 54 And once this mortal nature
is clothed in immortality,[p] the word of Scripture will be fulfilled:
"Death is swallowed up in victory."[q] 55 "Death, where is your conquest?
Death,[r] where is your sting?"[s] 56 The sting of death is sin, and the
power of sin is the Law. 57 But thanks be to God, who gives us the
victory through our Lord Jesus Christ!
58 Therefore, my dear brothers and sisters, stand firm and unshakable,
always excelling in the Lord's work, aware that your toil in the Lord
is not wasted.

Notes

- a (15:7) James: Hebrew *Yaakov* (Jacob), traditionally "he grasps the heel" or "may he protect"; here the Lord's brother (Gal 1:19).
- b (15:8) Born out of due time: Greek *ektrōma*, a premature or stillborn birth; perhaps a term of abuse used of Paul.
- c (15:18) Died in Christ: literally "fallen asleep in Christ."
- d (15:22) Adam: Hebrew, "human being," related to *adamah*, "ground."
- e (15:25) Ps 110:1.
- f (15:27) Ps 8:6.
- g (15:29) Baptized on behalf of the dead: the practice referred to is unknown, and its meaning has been widely debated.
- h (15:32) Fought with wild beasts at Ephesus: probably figurative, for fierce opposition.
- i (15:32) Isa 22:13.
- j (15:33) A line from the comic poet Menander (*Thaïs*), which had become proverbial.
- k (15:44) Natural: Greek *psychikos*, "belonging to the soul (*psychē*)," that is, animated by ordinary life; so also in v. 46.
- l (15:45) Gen 2:7, with "first" and "Adam" added.
- m (15:47) Out of heaven: many later manuscripts read "the Lord out of heaven."
- n (15:49) Let us also bear: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus, Claromontanus and most manuscripts (as reported); Vaticanus and some others read "we shall also bear," a difference of one vowel in Greek (*phoresōmen* / *phoresomen*) which many editors prefer on grounds of context.
- o (15:51) We shall not all fall asleep, but we shall all be changed: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46 (in part), Vaticanus and most manuscripts (as reported). Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and some others (as reported) read "we shall all fall asleep, but not all of us shall be changed," and the original hand of Claromontanus and the Latin Vulgate (as reported) read "we shall all rise, but not all of us shall be changed." P46 is reported to read "we shall all not fall asleep, but not all shall be changed." The variants apparently arose because Paul's generation had in fact died.

- p (15:54) Clothed in immortality: the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, the original hand of Sinaiticus and others (as reported), lacks the words "and this perishable nature is clothed in the imperishable," which most manuscripts include before this phrase.
- q (15:54) Isa 25:8, in a form close to the later Greek versions of Theodotion and Aquila.
- r (15:55) Death: many later manuscripts read "Hades."
- s (15:55) Hos 13:14, adapted from the Greek Old Testament.

Chapter 16

1 As for the collection for the saints: follow the directions I gave the
churches of Galatia. 2 On the first day of every week, each of you
is to set something aside at home, storing up whatever he has been
able to spare, so that collections will not have to be made when I
arrive. 3 On my arrival I will send those you endorse, with letters of
recommendation, to deliver your gift to Jerusalem. 4 And if it seems
right that I should make the journey as well, they will travel with me.
5 I will come to you after passing through Macedonia, since I intend to
pass through Macedonia, 6 and perhaps I will remain with you a while,
or even winter with you, so that you may speed me on to wherever
I travel next. 7 I would rather not see you only briefly on my way
through; I am hoping to stay with you for a time, Lord permitting. 8
But I will remain in Ephesus until Pentecost,[a] 9 because a wide door for
effective work has opened to me, and there are many who oppose me.
10 Should Timothy come, make sure he has no reason for fear among
you; he is working at the Lord's work as I am. 11 No one is to treat him
with contempt. Speed him on his journey peacefully so he can rejoin
me, since I am waiting for him with the brothers.
12 Concerning our brother Apollos, I strongly encouraged him to come
to you with the other brothers, but he was quite unwilling[b] to come
now. He will come when the opportunity arises.
13 Keep alert; stand firm in the faith; show courage; be strong. 14 Let all
that you do be done in love.
15 You are aware that Stephanas' household were the first converts
in Achaia,[c] and that they have appointed themselves to minister to
the saints. So I appeal to you, brothers, 16 to subordinate yourselves to

people like these, and to all who labor and toil alongside them. 17 I am glad that Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus[d] have arrived, because they have made up for your absence. 18 They have put fresh heart into me, and into you too. Value men like these.

19 Greetings to you from the churches of Asia.[e] Aquila and Prisca,[f] and the church in their home, greet you heartily in the Lord. 20 All the brothers here send you greetings. Greet one another with a holy kiss.

21 This greeting is in my own hand: Paul. 22 A curse on anyone who does not love the Lord![g] *Marana tha!*[h] 23 The grace of the Lord Jesus[i] be with you. 24 My love be with you all in Christ Jesus.[j]

Notes

- a (16:8) Pentecost: Greek, "fiftieth (day)," the Jewish Festival of Weeks (Shavuot), seven weeks after Passover.
- b (16:12) His will: or "God's will"; the Greek says simply "it was not at all the will."
- c (16:15) First converts in Achaia: literally "the firstfruits of Achaia," the Roman province of southern Greece, of which Corinth was the capital.
- d (16:17) Fortunatus, and Achaicus: *Fortunatus* is Latin, "fortunate"; *Achaicus* is Greek, "the Achaean," perhaps a name for a freedman.
- e (16:19) Asia: the Roman province in western Asia Minor, whose capital was Ephesus.
- f (16:19) Aquila and Prisca: *Aquila* is Latin, "eagle"; *Prisca* (diminutive *Priscilla*, Acts 18:2) is Latin, "ancient, venerable." Many later manuscripts read "Priscilla." They had lived in Corinth (Acts 18:1–3).
- g (16:22) A curse: Greek *anathema*, "let him be accursed."
- h (16:22) *Marana tha*: Aramaic, "Our Lord, come!" The Greek letters can also be divided *maran atha*, "Our Lord has come" (or "is coming"). Compare Rev 22:20.
- i (16:23) The Lord Jesus: many later manuscripts read "our Lord Jesus Christ."
- j (16:24) In Christ Jesus: many manuscripts add "Amen."

2 Corinthians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul, by God's will an apostle of Christ Jesus, and from
Timothy[a] our brother, to God's church at Corinth,[b] together with all
the saints throughout Achaia:[c] 2 grace to you and peace from God our
Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.
3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father
of mercies and the God who gives every comfort,[d] 4 who comforts us
in all our trouble, so that we in turn can comfort those in any trouble
through the comfort with which God himself comforts us. 5 For just
as Christ's sufferings overflow into our lives, so too through Christ
our comfort overflows. 6 If we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and
salvation; if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which takes
effect when you patiently bear the same sufferings that we also suffer.
7 Our hope for you is unshaken; we know that as partners in the
sufferings you are partners in the comfort too.
8 We would not have you unaware, brothers, of the trouble that came
upon us in Asia.[e] We were weighed down far past our strength, so
much so that we gave up hope even of staying alive. 9 In our own
minds we had heard our death sentence pronounced. That happened
to make us trust not in ourselves but in the God who brings the dead
back to life. 10 He rescued us from so deadly a peril, and he will rescue
us; on him we have fixed our hope that he will go on rescuing us,
11 as you too join in helping us by your prayers, so that thanks may
be given on our behalf by many people for the favor granted to us
through the prayers of many.
12 Here is our boast: our conscience testifies that we have behaved in
the world, and most of all with you, with purity[f] and sincerity that
come from God, relying not on human cleverness but on God's grace.
13 Nothing we write to you is beyond what you can read and take in,

and I hope you will take it in completely, [14] just as you have partly understood us, that we are a reason for you to be proud, as you are for us, when our Lord Jesus comes.[g]

[15] It was in this confidence that I intended to come first to you, so that you might have a second joy,[h] [16] My plan was to visit you on the way to Macedonia, then to return to you after Macedonia, and to be sent on by you toward Judea. [17] When I planned this, was I being fickle? Or do I make my plans in a worldly way, ready to say "Yes, yes" and "No, no" in the same breath? [18] God is faithful, and as surely as he is, our message to you was never "Yes" that was also "No." [19] For the Son of God, Jesus Christ, whom Silvanus,[i] Timothy, and I announced to you, was not "Yes and No"; in him it has always been a firm "Yes." [20] For however many are God's promises, in him they find their "Yes." That is why it is through him also that we say the "Amen" to God, for his glory. [21] Now it is God who makes both us and you secure in Christ, and who has anointed us; [22] He has stamped us with his seal, and has put his Spirit in our hearts as the first installment of what is to come.[j]

[23] With my life at stake I call God to bear witness: I stayed away from Corinth in order to spare you. [24] Not that we lord it over your faith; we are working with you for your joy, for it is by faith that you stand firm.

Notes

- a (1:1) Timothy: Greek, "one who honors God."
- b (1:1) Corinth: capital of the Roman province of Achaia.
- c (1:1) Achaia: the Roman province of southern Greece.
- d (1:3) Every comfort: Greek *paraklēsis*, which can mean comfort, encouragement, or appeal; the related verb occurs throughout vv. 3–7.
- e (1:8) Asia: the Roman province in western Asia Minor, whose capital was Ephesus.
- f (1:12) Holiness: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts read "simplicity" or "frankness."
- g (1:14) Our Lord Jesus: many manuscripts add "Christ."
- h (1:15) Second joy: so the Westcott–Hort text, with the corrected Sinaiticus, Vaticanus and a few others (as reported); most manuscripts read *charin*, "favor" or "benefit" ("a second benefit"), and the two words differ by one letter in Greek.

- i (1:19) Silvanus: Latin form of *Silas* (Acts 15:22), probably from Aramaic *sheila*, “asked for”; associated in Latin with *silva*, “forest.”
- j (1:22) The first installment of what is to come: Greek *arrabōn*, a first installment that guarantees the rest.

Chapter 2

1 So I made up my mind not to pay you another painful visit. 2 For if
I cause you pain, who is left to cheer me except the very one I have
pained? 3 And I wrote just as I did[a] so that when I came I would not be
pained by those who ought to make me glad, for I am confident about
all of you that my joy is the joy of you all. 4 Out of deep affliction and
heartache I wrote to you, shedding many tears,[b] not to grieve you but
so that you would know how overflowing my love for you is.
5 Whoever has given grief has grieved not me alone but, to a degree
(I do not want to press the point too hard), every one of you. 6 For
such a person this punishment by the majority is enough, 7 so that
now, instead, you should rather forgive and comfort him, or he may
be overwhelmed by excessive grief. 8 So I urge you to confirm your
love for him. 9 For this was my purpose in writing too: to test you
and find out whether you are obedient in everything. 10 Whomever
you pardon, I pardon too. And what I have pardoned, if there was
anything for me to pardon, I have pardoned for your sake before
Christ, 11 so that Satan may not gain the advantage over us; for we are
not ignorant of his designs.
12 When I came to Troas[c] for the gospel of Christ, though a door was
opened for me in the Lord, 13 I had no peace of mind, since my brother
Titus[d] was nowhere to be found; so I took leave of them and set out
for Macedonia.
14 But thanks to God, who constantly leads us in victory as prisoners
in Christ’s parade[e] and uses us to spread the aroma of knowing him
everywhere. 15 We are Christ’s sweet scent offered up to God, both
among people on the way to salvation and among people on the way
to ruin: 16 to the one, a smell of death leading to death; to the other,
a fragrance of life leading to life. And who is equal to such a task?
17 For we are not like so many,[f] peddling the word of God for profit;

we speak in Christ with sincerity, as men sent from God, in God's presence.

Notes

- a (2:3) I wrote just as I did: this and v. 4 refer to a letter written "with many tears" between 1 Corinthians and this letter, often called the "tearful letter." See the introduction.
- b (2:4) Shedding many tears: see the note on v. 3.
- c (2:12) Troas: Alexandria Troas, a port in northwestern Asia Minor.
- d (2:13) Titus: a Latin name, of uncertain meaning; a Gentile co-worker of Paul (Gal 2:1–3).
- e (2:14) Triumphal procession: the Roman victory parade, in which captives were led along; the image may be of God leading his apostles either as captives or as fellow victors.
- f (2:17) So many: many manuscripts read "the rest."

Chapter 3

1 Is this the start of more self-commendation? Or must we, as certain
others do, present letters of reference to you, or ask you for them? 2
Our letter is you yourselves, inscribed on our hearts,[a] recognized and
read by all the world. 3 It is clear that you are Christ's letter, delivered
by us, inscribed not in ink but by the living God's Spirit, not on stone
tablets but on the tablets of human hearts.[b]
4 That is the kind of trust we place in God, through Christ. 5 Not that
we are competent by ourselves to reckon anything as coming from
us; our competence comes from God, 6 who has made us competent
as ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit. For
the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.
7 The ministry that brought death was engraved in letters on stones,
and yet it came in glory, so much so that the sons of Israel were unable
to fix their eyes on Moses' face because of the glory shining there,
glory that was fading.[c] 8 Then surely the Spirit's ministry will have
still greater glory! 9 If the ministry that brought condemnation was
glorious, far richer in glory is the ministry that brings righteousness.
10 In fact, set beside this surpassing glory, the thing that was once
glorified has lost its glory altogether. 11 For if what was fading away
came with glory, much more does what lasts remain in glory.

12 Possessing a hope like this, we speak out with complete frankness.
13 We are not like Moses, who would cover his face with a veil to stop
the sons of Israel from staring at the end of a glory that was being
abolished.[d] 14 But their minds were hardened. For to this day, when
the old covenant is read, that same veil remains unlifted, because only
in Christ is it done away with. 15 To this present day a veil covers
their hearts whenever Moses is read aloud; 16 but whenever someone
turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.[e] 17 Now the Lord is the Spirit,
and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom. 18 And all of us,
with unveiled faces reflecting[f] as in a mirror the glory of the Lord,
are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory
to another, as it comes from the Lord, the Spirit.[g]

Notes

- a (3:2) Our hearts: a few manuscripts, including Sinaiticus (as reported), read "your hearts."
- b (3:3) Tablets of human hearts: literally "tablets that are hearts of flesh," echoing Exod 24:12; 31:18 and Ezek 11:19; 36:26; compare Jer 31:33.
- c (3:7) Fading: compare Exod 34:29–35.
- d (3:13) The end of a glory that was being abolished: or "the outcome of what was being abolished," or "the goal of what was fading."
- e (3:16) Taken away: echoing Exod 34:34, where "the Lord" is Yahweh; the subject ("someone," or "Moses," or "their heart") is unexpressed in Greek.
- f (3:18) Reflecting: or "beholding."
- g (3:18) The Lord, the Spirit: or "the Spirit of the Lord," or "the Lord who is the Spirit."

Chapter 4

1 Because we hold this ministry by God's mercy, we never give up. 2
We have renounced shameful, underhanded ways; we do not practice
cunning or tamper with God's word; but by openly declaring the
truth we commend ourselves to everyone's conscience in the sight of
God. 3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are
perishing. 4 The god of this present age has blinded the unbelieving
minds of these people, so that the light of the gospel, which displays
the glory of Christ, God's image, does not dawn on them. 5 It is not
ourselves that we proclaim; we proclaim Jesus Christ as Lord, and
ourselves as your servants[a] on account of Jesus. 6 For the God who

commanded, “Let light shine from the darkness,”[b] has made light shine in our hearts so that we can illuminate the knowledge of God’s glory shining from the face of Christ.[c]
7 But we hold this treasure in clay jars,[d] to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and does not come from us. 8 We are hard pressed on every side, but not hemmed in; at a loss, but not at our wits’ end; 9 hunted down, but not abandoned; knocked to the ground, but not destroyed; 10 always carrying about in our body the dying of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body. 11 While we live, we are continually being surrendered to death because of Jesus, so that Jesus’ life may be displayed in our mortal flesh as well. 12 Death, then, is busy in us, and life is busy in you. 13 We have the same spirit of trust that the Scripture describes: “I believed, therefore I spoke.”[e] We also believe and therefore speak, 14 for we know that the one who raised the Lord Jesus[f] will raise us as well with Jesus and place us, together with you, in his presence. 15 All this is for your benefit, so that as grace spreads to more and more people it may make thanksgiving abound all the more, and God may be glorified.
16 That is why we never give up. Though our outward person is decaying, our inward person is renewed from one day to the next. 17 The light trouble of this passing moment is working out for us a glory that is eternal and weighty, past all comparison, 18 for our gaze is fixed not on what is visible but on what is invisible. What is visible lasts for a time; what is invisible lasts for ever.

Notes

- a (4:5) Servants: literally “slaves.”
- b (4:6) Gen 1:3; compare Isa 9:2.
- c (4:6) Face of Christ: many manuscripts read “Jesus Christ,” and some “Christ Jesus.”
- d (4:7) Clay jars: or “earthenware vessels,” cheap and fragile pottery.
- e (4:13) Ps 116:10 (115:1 Greek), following the Greek Old Testament.
- f (4:14) The Lord Jesus: “Lord” is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.

Chapter 5

1 We know that if the tent that is our earthly house is taken down, we have a building from God, a house not built by human hands,

everlasting in the heavens. 2 Meanwhile we groan in this tent, longing
to put on over it our dwelling from heaven, 3 assuming that, once we
have put it on,[a] we will not be found naked. 4 For while we remain
in this tent we groan under our burden, not because we wish to be
unclothed, but because we wish to be further clothed, so that what is
mortal may be swallowed up by life. 5 God is the one who prepared
us for exactly this, and who gave us the Spirit as a down payment
guaranteeing what is coming.
6 So we are always full of courage. We know that while we are at
home in the body we are away from the Lord, 7 for our life is guided
by faith, not by sight. 8 We are confident, I repeat, and would rather
be away from the body and at home with the Lord. 9 Whether we are
in our home or away from it, then, our one ambition is to be pleasing
to him. 10 Every one of us must be exposed to view before Christ's
tribunal, so that each person may receive his due for the deeds done
through the body, good or evil.
11 Since we know the fear of the Lord, we seek to win people over.
God sees us as we are, and I trust that your consciences see us so as
well. 12 We are not recommending ourselves to you once more; rather,
we are giving you a reason to be proud of us, so that you can respond
to those who boast about outward show rather than inner reality. 13
If we have lost our senses, that is God's concern; if we are sober-
minded, that is for your benefit. 14 For Christ's love holds us fast, since
we have reached this conclusion: one man died for all, and therefore
all have died. 15 His death was for all, so that the living should stop
living to please themselves and live instead for the one who died and
rose again on their behalf.
16 So from now on we regard no one from a merely human point of
view. Even if we once regarded Christ in that way, we no longer do.
17 So if anyone is in Christ, there is a new creation.[b] The old things
have gone; look, new things have come into being![c] 18 Everything is
God's doing. He has reconciled us to himself by means of Christ, and
has assigned to us the service of reconciling others: 19 God was in
Christ, reconciling the world to himself,[d] no longer charging people
with their offenses, and he has placed in our hands the message of

reconciliation. 20 We are envoys, then, representing Christ, and God
is appealing to you through our words. On Christ's behalf we plead
with you: be reconciled to God. 21 The one who knew no sin God
made to be sin[e] for our sake, so that in him we might become the
righteousness of God.

Notes

- a (5:3) Once we have put it on: so the Westcott–Hort text and most manuscripts (as reported), *endysamenoi*; the original hand of Claromontanus and a few others read *ekdysamenoi*, "once we have taken it off," which some editors prefer as less obvious.
- b (5:17) There is a new creation: or "he is a new creature."
- c (5:17) New things have come into being: many later manuscripts read "all things have become new."
- d (5:19) God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself: or "in Christ God was reconciling the world to himself."
- e (5:21) Sin: or "a sin offering," a sense the Hebrew word for "sin" can bear (for example Lev 4:24).

Chapter 6

1 As God's fellow workers, then, we also appeal to you not to let the
grace of God you have received go for nothing. 2 For he says, "At the
moment of my favor I heard you, and on the day of rescue I helped
you."[a] Listen, now is the time of favor; now is the day of rescue! 3 We
give nobody any cause for offense in anything, so that our service
may not be discredited. 4 Instead, as God's servants we commend
ourselves in every way: by great endurance, in afflictions, in hard-
ships, in distresses, 5 in floggings, in imprisonments, in riots, in labors,
in sleepless nights, in hunger; 6 in integrity, in understanding, in
forbearance, in goodness, in the Holy Spirit, in love without pretense,
7 in the message of truth, in God's power; armed with righteousness
in right hand and left; 8 through honor and dishonor, through slander
and praise; treated as impostors, and yet true; 9 as unknown, and yet
well known; as dying, and look, we live on; as punished, and yet not
put to death; 10 as grieving, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making
many rich; as having nothing, yet possessing everything.
11 We have been completely open with you, Corinthians; we have
welcomed you with an open heart. 12 It is not on our side that you

are cramped; you are cramped in your own affections. 13 In return (I
speak as to my children), open wide your hearts as well.
14 Do not be yoked unequally with unbelievers.[b] For what partnership
can righteousness have with lawlessness? What fellowship has light
with darkness? 15 What harmony is there between Christ and Beliar?
[c] What does a believer share with an unbeliever? 16 What common
ground can God's temple share with idols? For we[d] are the sanctuary
of the living God; as God declared: "I will dwell among them and walk
with them, and I will be their God, and they will be my people."[e] 17 So
"Leave their company and keep yourselves apart, says the Lord, and
lay no hand on what is unclean;[f] then I will receive you,[g] 18 I will be
a Father to you, and to me you will be sons and daughters, declares
the Lord Almighty."[h]

Notes

- a (6:2) Isa 49:8, following the Greek Old Testament. In the Hebrew text the speaker is Yahweh.
- b (6:14) Yoked unequally with unbelievers: compare Deut 22:10; Lev 19:19.
- c (6:15) Beliar: a form of *Belial* (Hebrew, "worthlessness"), used in Jewish writings of the period as a name for Satan.
- d (6:16) We: many manuscripts read "you."
- e (6:16) Lev 26:11–12; compare Ezek 37:27.
- f (6:17) Isa 52:11. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.
- g (6:17) Ezek 20:34, following the Greek Old Testament.
- h (6:18) 2 Sam 7:14, 8; compare Isa 43:6. "The Lord Almighty" renders the Greek Old Testament's *kyrios pantokratōr*, which translates the Hebrew "Yahweh of hosts."

Chapter 7

1 These, dear friends, are the promises we hold; so let us purify
ourselves of everything that pollutes flesh or spirit, and in reverence
for God bring our holiness to completion.
2 Open your hearts to us. Not one person have we wronged, corrupted,
or exploited. 3 I am not saying this to condemn you; I have told you
before that you are in our hearts, to die together and to live together.
4 My frankness with you is great, and great is my pride in you. I am
full to the brim with encouragement; through all our troubles my joy
overflows.

5 For even when we came into Macedonia, our flesh had no relief; we
were afflicted at every turn: conflicts outside, fears within. 6 Yet God,
the comforter of the lowly, gave us comfort when Titus arrived, 7 and
not only by his arrival but also by the comfort he had received from
you, as he told us of your longing, your sorrow, your zeal for me, so
that I rejoiced still more. 8 Granted that my letter grieved you, I have
no regrets about it. I did regret it at the time (for I see that the letter
pained you, if only briefly),[a] 9 but now I am glad, not that you were
pained, but that the pain brought you to repentance. Your sorrow was
of God's kind, so that we did you no damage in any respect. 10 For
grief as God intends it produces a repentance that leads to salvation
and leaves no regret, but the world's grief produces death. 11 Look
at what this godly sorrow has brought about in you: such diligence,
such eagerness to be cleared, such outrage, such dread, such yearning,
such ardor, such determination to set things right! In every way you
have proved yourselves blameless in this affair. 12 So my letter was
written not for the sake of the offender or for the sake of the injured
party, but so that before God you yourselves might see clearly how
devoted you are to us.[b] 13 This is what has brought us comfort. And
on top of our comfort, we were made gladder still by Titus' gladness,
because all of you have refreshed his spirit. 14 Whatever I bragged
about you to him, you have not embarrassed me; just as everything
we told you was true, so what we boasted to Titus about you turned
out to be accurate as well. 15 His heart goes out to you even more as
he recalls how all of you obeyed, and how you welcomed him in awe
and trembling. 16 I rejoice that in everything I can have confidence
in you.

Notes

- a (7:8) If only briefly: the punctuation of vv. 8–9 is uncertain; the sentence may instead run "even if I regretted it, I see that the letter pained you, if only briefly; now I am glad…"
- b (7:12) How devoted you are to us: literally "your earnestness on our behalf"; many later manuscripts read "our earnestness on your behalf."

Chapter 8

1 Brothers, we want you to know about the grace God has bestowed
on the churches of Macedonia. 2 In the midst of a severe ordeal of
affliction, their overflowing joy and their deep poverty have welled
up in a wealth of generosity. 3 I can vouch that they gave what they
could afford, and even more than that, entirely on their own initiative,
4 begging us with much entreaty for the privilege of taking part in
this service to the saints. 5 And they did not do merely what we had
hoped; they gave themselves first to the Lord and then, by God's will,
to us. 6 So we have urged Titus that, as he had made a beginning, he
should also bring this act of grace to completion among you. 7 You
excel in everything: in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in every kind
of eagerness, and in the love from us that lives in you.[a] See that you
excel in this act of grace as well.

8 I am not saying this as an order; I am testing the genuineness of your
love by the eagerness of others. 9 You are familiar with the generosity
of our Lord Jesus Christ:[b] he was rich, yet for your sakes he made
himself poor, so that by his poverty you might be made rich. 10 And
in this matter I am giving you my advice. It is to your advantage,
since a year ago you were the first not only to act but even to want to
act. 11 So now finish the task, so that the eagerness of your intention
may be matched by its accomplishment, as your means allow. 12 For
if the willingness is there, a gift is acceptable in proportion to what a
person has, not what he does not have. 13 The aim is not that others
should have relief while you are hard pressed, but that there should
be equality. 14 At the present time your surplus can meet their need,
so that their surplus may in turn meet your need, and so there may
be equality. 15 As Scripture says, "The one who collected a lot did not
have too much, and the one who collected a little did not have too
little."[c]

16 But thanks be to God, who puts into Titus' heart the same eager
concern for you that I have. 17 For he not only welcomed our appeal;
being very eager himself, he is going to you of his own accord. 18 Along
with him we are sending the brother whose service in the gospel
has won him praise in every church. 19 More than that, he has been

appointed by the churches to travel with us as we administer this act of grace, for the glory of the Lord himself and to show our goodwill. 20 We are taking this precaution so that no one may blame us about the way we are administering this generous gift. 21 Our purpose is to do what is right not just before the Lord but before human eyes as well.[d] 22 With them we are also sending our brother, whom we have repeatedly put to the test in numerous matters and found keen, and who is now far keener because of his great trust in you. 23 As for Titus, he is my partner and fellow worker in your service; as for our brothers, they are envoys[e] of the churches, a glory to Christ. 24 Show them, then, in front of the churches, how real your love is and why we take pride in you.

Notes

- a (8:7) The love from us that lives in you: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46 and Vaticanus (as reported); many manuscripts read "your love for us."
- b (8:9) Our Lord Jesus Christ: "Christ" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- c (8:15) Exod 16:18.
- d (8:21) Prov 3:4, following the Greek Old Testament.
- e (8:23) Envoys: Greek *apostoloi*, "apostles," here in the general sense of messengers sent by the churches.

Chapter 9

1 It is quite unnecessary for me to write to you about this service to the saints, 2 I am well aware how willing you are; I keep boasting of you to the Macedonians that Achaia has been prepared since a year ago, and your enthusiasm has stirred up most of them. 3 Still, I am sending the brothers, so that our boast of you on this point may not be proved hollow, and so that you will be prepared, just as I kept saying. 4 Otherwise, if any Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared, we (to say nothing of you) would be humiliated for having been so confident.[a] 5 I therefore judged it needful to ask the brothers to go to you ahead of me and get your promised gift ready beforehand, so that it may be on hand as a free gift, not one extracted from you.[b]

6 Remember this: whoever sows sparingly will reap sparingly, and whoever sows generously will reap generously. 7 Each one should

give as he has made up his mind, not grudgingly or under compulsion, for "God loves a cheerful giver."[c] 8 God has the power to cause all kinds of grace to abound toward you, so that in every circumstance you always have all you need and have plenty left for every good deed. 9 As it is written, "He has scattered his gifts, he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures for ever."[d] 10 He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food[e] will supply and multiply your seed and increase the harvest of your righteousness. 11 In every way you will be made rich enough for every kind of generosity, and your generosity, passed on by us, will lead to thanksgiving to God. 12 For the carrying out of this public service is not only filling up what the saints lack; it also spills over into abundant thanks to God. 13 Through the proof that this service provides, they will glorify God for the obedience of your confession of the gospel of Christ and for the generosity of your sharing with them and with all, 14 and their longing for you and their prayers for you will reflect God's grace, which surpasses all bounds in you. 15 Thanks be to God for his indescribable gift!

Notes

- a (9:4) So confident: many later manuscripts add "in this boasting."
- b (9:5) Extracted from you: literally "as greed," that is, as an extortion.
- c (9:7) Prov 22:8, in the Greek Old Testament only.
- d (9:9) Ps 112:9.
- e (9:10) Bread for food: Isa 55:10.

Chapter 10

1 It is I myself, Paul, who plead with you by the meekness and kindness of Christ, I who am "lowly" in your presence but "daring" toward you from a distance. 2 I beg you that when I am present I may not have to show the boldness I count on displaying against certain people who reckon that we behave by worldly standards. 3 For though we live in the flesh, we do not wage war by the flesh. 4 The weapons we fight with are not of the flesh, but powerful through God for tearing down strongholds. We demolish arguments 5 and every lofty barrier raised up against the knowledge of God, and we take every thought prisoner to make it obey Christ, 6 and we stand ready to punish every disobedience, once your obedience is complete.

7 Look at what is right before your eyes.[a] If anyone is sure that he belongs to Christ, let him think again and consider that, as he is Christ's, so are we. 8 Even if I boast rather freely about our authority, which the Lord gave for building you up and not for pulling you down, I will not be put to shame. 9 I do not want to seem to be frightening you with my letters. 10 For "His letters," they say, "are weighty and forceful, but his bodily presence is feeble and his speaking amounts to nothing." 11 Let such a person understand that what we are in word by letter when absent, we are also in action when present.

12 We would not venture to rank ourselves or measure ourselves against certain of those who write their own testimonials. They gauge themselves by each other and rate themselves against each other, and they have no sense.[b] 13 We, however, will not boast beyond limits, but will keep to the limits of the field[c] God has assigned to us as our measure, a field that reaches even as far as you. 14 We are not stretching beyond our bounds, as if we had never reached you; in fact we came as far as you, the first to bring the gospel of Christ. 15 We do not boast beyond limits in other people's labors. Our hope is that as your faith grows, our field among you may be greatly enlarged, 16 so that we may carry the gospel to regions past you, and not take credit for ground another has already worked. 17 "Whoever boasts must make his boast in the Lord."[d] 18 Approval comes not to the person who recommends himself, but to the person the Lord recommends.

Notes

- a (10:7) Look at what is right before your eyes: or, as a question, "Are you looking at things as they appear on the surface?" or, as a command, "Look at the facts."
- b (10:12) They have no sense: some Western witnesses (as reported) lack these words and the first words of v. 13, so that the sentence runs: "…but we gauge ourselves by ourselves and rate ourselves against ourselves, and will not boast beyond limits…"
- c (10:13) Field: Greek *kanōn*, a measuring rule, and so a measured area or sphere of work.
- d (10:17) Jer 9:24; compare 1 Cor 1:31. In the Hebrew text, "the Lord" is Yahweh.

Chapter 11

1 I wish you would bear with a little foolishness from me! Do bear with
me. 2 I feel for you a jealousy that is God's own, for I promised you in
marriage to one husband, to present you to Christ as a pure virgin. 3
My fear is that, just as the snake tricked Eve[a] with its craftiness, your
thoughts may be corrupted and drawn away from single-minded and
pure[b] loyalty to Christ. 4 Someone arrives proclaiming a Jesus other
than the Jesus we proclaimed, or you take in a spirit unlike the Spirit
you took in before, or a gospel unlike the gospel you welcomed, and
you tolerate it beautifully! 5 Yet in my estimation I fall short of these
superlative apostles in nothing. 6 I may lack training as a speaker, but
I do not lack knowledge; we have made that clear to you in every way
and in every respect.
7 Was it a sin, then, that I lowered myself to lift you up, proclaiming
God's good news to you without charging you anything? 8 Other
churches I plundered, taking pay from them so as to minister to you.
9 While I was with you and ran short, I was a drain on nobody; my
needs were met by the brothers who arrived from Macedonia. I have
kept myself from weighing on you in any way, and I will keep on
doing so. 10 By the truth of Christ that is in me, nobody throughout
Achaia shall stop me from making this boast. 11 And why? Because I
do not love you? God knows I do! 12 I will continue as I am doing, so as
to deny any opening to those who are looking for one, so that in their
boasting they may be found to work on the same terms as we do. 13
Men like that are sham apostles, dishonest laborers, masquerading
as Christ's apostles. 14 And no wonder, for Satan himself disguises
himself as an angel of light. 15 It is hardly surprising, then, if his
ministers masquerade as ministers of righteousness. They will end as
their works deserve.
16 Again I say, nobody should think me a fool. Or if you must, then
welcome me even as a fool, so that I may boast a little myself. 17 What
I am saying in this boastful confidence I am saying not as the Lord
would, but as in foolishness. 18 Since many boast according to the
flesh, I too will boast. 19 Wise as you are, you are glad to tolerate fools.
20 You tolerate a man who makes slaves of you, who eats you up, who

snatches what is yours, who lords it over you, who slaps your face.
21 I admit, to our discredit, that we have been weak in comparison!
Still, whatever anyone ventures to boast about (this is fool's talk), I
will venture it too.
22 Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they
descendants of Abraham? So am I. 23 Are they ministers of Christ?
(Now I am raving.) I am a better one: in labors more abundantly, in
prisons more often, in beatings beyond counting, and many times
facing death. 24 From the Jews I received thirty-nine lashes[c] on five
occasions. 25 Three times I was beaten with rods; once I was stoned;
three times I was shipwrecked; a night and a day I spent adrift at
sea; 26 I have been constantly on the road, at risk from flooded rivers,
at risk from robbers, at risk from my countrymen, at risk from the
nations, at risk in towns, at risk in open country, at risk on the sea,
at risk among sham brothers; 27 I have known labor and weariness,
many nights without sleep, hunger and thirst, frequent fasting, cold
and lack of clothing. 28 Besides everything else, I carry the pressure
of care for all the churches, bearing down on me each day. 29 When
someone is weak, am I not weak as well? When someone is tripped
up, am I not on fire?
30 If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness.
31 The God and Father of the Lord Jesus, he who is blessed for ever,
knows that I am not lying. 32 In Damascus the governor[d] under King
Aretas[e] was guarding the city of the Damascenes in order to seize me,
33 but I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall and
escaped his hands.

Notes

- a (11:3) Eve: Hebrew *Chavvah*, associated with *chai*, "living" (Gen 3:20).
- b (11:3) Single-minded and pure: "and pure" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text; many manuscripts lack it, and others put the two words in reverse order.
- c (11:24) Thirty-nine lashes: literally "forty less one," keeping within the limit of forty set in Deut 25:3.
- d (11:32) The governor: Greek *ethnarchēs*, a ruler or representative of a people.
- e (11:32) Aretas: Aretas IV, king of the Nabateans (about 9 BC–AD 40), whose capital was Petra. Compare Acts 9:23–25.

Chapter 12

1 Boast I must.[a] Nothing is gained by it, but I will move on to visions
and revelations granted by the Lord. 2 I know a man in Christ who
fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven; I do not know
whether it happened in the body or outside the body; God knows. 3
And I know that this man (whether in the body or apart from the body
I cannot say; God knows) 4 was snatched up into paradise[b] and heard
words too sacred for speech, which no human being is permitted to
utter. 5 About such a man I will boast, but about myself I will not
boast, except of my weaknesses. 6 Even if I should choose to boast, I
would be no fool, for I would be telling the truth. But I hold back, so
that nobody may credit me with more than he sees in me or hears
from me, 7 even given the surpassing greatness of what was revealed.[c]
So, to keep me from becoming overly elated, I was handed a thorn
in the flesh, Satan's messenger, to beat me about, so that I would not
become overly elated. 8 Three times I pleaded with the Lord about
this, asking that it might leave me. 9 His word to me was, "My grace
suffices for you, for my power reaches its completion in weakness."
Gladly, then, I will rather boast of my weaknesses, so that Christ's
power may rest upon me like a tent. 10 That is why, for Christ's sake,
I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and
pressures; for when I am weak, then it is that I am strong.
11 I have turned into a fool; you drove me to it. I ought to have had
your commendation, for I came behind those superlative apostles in
nothing, even though I am nothing. 12 The marks of a true apostle
were produced among you with all perseverance, by signs, wonders,
and mighty works. 13 How were you put at a disadvantage compared
with the rest of the churches, apart from this: I personally laid no
burden on you? Pardon me for this injustice!
14 See, I am ready to come to you for this third time, and I will not be
a drain on you. It is not your possessions I am after but you. Children
are not obliged to save up for their parents; parents save up for their
children. 15 For my part, I will most gladly spend and be spent for your
souls. If I love you more, am I to be loved less? 16 Very well, then: I did
not burden you myself. Yet, crafty as I am, I caught you by trickery,

did I? 17 Of those I dispatched to you, was there one through whom
I took advantage of you? 18 I asked Titus to visit you and sent the
brother along. Did Titus take advantage of you? Were we not guided
by one Spirit, and did we not tread in the same tracks?
19 Have you been supposing all this time that we are defending our-
selves before you? We are speaking before God in Christ, and all of it,
dear friends, is for your upbuilding. 20 My fear is that on my arrival I
may find you otherwise than I want, and you may find me otherwise
than you want; that there may be strife, envy, fits of temper, factions,
backbiting, whispering, conceit, and turmoil. 21 I am afraid that on my
return my God may bring me low in front of you, and that I may
grieve for many who were sinning before and have not turned away
from the uncleanness, fornication, and sensuality they indulged in.

Notes

- a (12:1) Boast I must: many manuscripts read "If I must boast," and some "I must boast, though it is not profitable."
- b (12:4) Paradise: from a Persian word for a walled garden; in the Greek Old Testament, the garden of Eden, and in Jewish writings, the abode of the righteous with God.
- c (12:7) What was revealed: the punctuation is disputed. These words may instead close v. 6 ("…more than he sees in me or hears from me, even given the extraordinary revelations") or begin a new sentence with v. 7, as here. Many manuscripts lack "For that reason."

Chapter 13

1 This will be the third time I am coming to you. "Every charge must
be established on the evidence of two or three witnesses."[a] 2 I warned
those who sinned before and all the rest, and I warn them now, absent
now as I was present on my second visit: if I come again, I will not
spare them, 3 because you are looking for evidence that it is Christ
who speaks in me. Toward you he is not feeble; he is mighty in your
midst. 4 For he was crucified in weakness, but he lives by God's power.
We too are weak in him, but we shall live with him by God's power
in dealing with you.[b]
5 Put yourselves under scrutiny to see whether you are living in the
faith; test yourselves. Can you not recognize that Jesus Christ is in

you? Unless, that is, you fail the test. 6 I hope you will come to
recognize that we have not failed it. 7 Our prayer to God is that you
will do no wrong; not that we may be seen to stand approved, but that
you may do good while we may look like failures. 8 We have no power
to act against the truth, only for the truth. 9 We are glad when we are
weak and you are strong. And this is what we pray for: your complete
restoration. 10 This is why I am writing from a distance: so that when
I arrive I will not need to be severe in exercising the authority the
Lord gave me for building you up, not for demolishing you.
11 Finally, brothers, farewell.[c] Set yourselves right, take my appeal to
heart, agree with one another, live in peace; and the God of love and
peace will be with you. 12 Greet one another with a holy kiss. 13 All the
saints send you greetings.[d]
14 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ,[e] the love of God, and the fellow-
ship of the Holy Spirit[f] be with you all.[g]

Notes

- a (13:1) Deut 19:15.
- b (13:4) In dealing with you: Greek *eis hymas*, bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- c (13:11) Farewell: or "rejoice."
- d (13:13) Greetings: in the Greek text, and in some translations, vv. 12–13 are numbered as v. 12, and v. 14 as v. 13.
- e (13:14) The Lord Jesus Christ: "Christ" is bracketed in the Westcott–Hort text.
- f (13:14) Fellowship of the Holy Spirit: or "sharing in the Holy Spirit."
- g (13:14) With you all: many manuscripts add "Amen."

Galatians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul,[a] an apostle[b] commissioned neither by people nor through
any human agent, but by Jesus Christ[c] and God the Father, who raised
him from the dead, 2 and all the brothers[d] who are with me, to the
churches of Galatia:[e] 3 May grace and peace be yours from God our
Father and from the Lord Jesus Christ,[f] 4 who gave himself for our
sins to rescue us from this present evil age, according to the will of
our God and Father, 5 to whom be the glory for ever and ever. Amen.
6 I am astonished that you are deserting so quickly the one who
summoned you by the grace of Christ, and defecting to a different
message,[g] 7 which is not another gospel at all. It is only that there are
some people who are unsettling you and want to twist the gospel of
Christ. 8 But even if we, or an angel from heaven, should proclaim to
you a gospel contrary to the one we proclaimed to you, let him be
accursed.[h] 9 As we have said before, so now I say again: if anyone is
proclaiming to you a gospel contrary to what you received, let him
be accursed.

10 Am I now looking for human approval, or for God's? Is it people I
am trying to please? Were I still courting people's favor, I could not
be Christ's servant.[i]

11 For I want you to know, brothers, that the gospel I proclaimed is
not of human origin. 12 No human being handed it to me, and no one
taught it to me; it came by a revelation from Jesus Christ.[j]

13 You have heard how I once lived as a follower of Judaism: how
violently I hunted down God's church and set out to ravage it. 14 I was
advancing in Judaism beyond many of my own age among my people,
and I was far more zealous for the traditions of my ancestors. 15 But
then God, who chose me while I was still in my mother's womb[k] and
called me through his grace, decided 16 to disclose his Son within me,

so that I would announce him among the nations.[l] At once, without talking it over with any mortal,[m] 17 nor did I go up to Jerusalem to those who were apostles before me. Instead I went away into Arabia,[n] and then returned to Damascus.

18 Three years later I did go up to Jerusalem, to become acquainted with Cephas,[o] and I spent fifteen days in his company. 19 Of the other apostles I saw no one, apart from James, the brother of the Lord.[p] 20 As for the things I write to you, look: before God, I am telling no lie. 21 Then I went into the regions of Syria and Cilicia.[q] 22 The churches in Judea that are in Christ still did not know my face. 23 All they had heard was this: "The one who used to persecute us now proclaims as good news the faith that he once set out to ravage." 24 And they glorified God because of me.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, "one who is sent," a messenger with authority from the one who sends him.
- c (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah." In Paul's letters it usually functions as part of Jesus' name and is rendered "Christ."
- d (1:2) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women; so throughout the letter.
- e (1:2) Galatia: a region and Roman province in central Asia Minor (modern Turkey), named after the Gauls (Celts) who settled there in the third century BC.
- f (1:3) From God our Father and from the Lord: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus. Many other manuscripts, reportedly including P46 and Vaticanus, read "from God the Father and our Lord."
- g (1:6) Gospel: Greek *euangelion*, "good news"; so throughout.
- h (1:8) Accursed: Greek *anathema*, something handed over to God for destruction, the Greek Old Testament's word for Hebrew *ḥerem* (Josh 6:17).
- i (1:10) Slave: Greek *doulos*, a slave or bond-servant, one wholly owned by a master.
- j (1:12) A revelation of Jesus Christ: either a revelation that came from Jesus Christ, or one in which Jesus Christ was revealed (compare verse 16).
- k (1:15) Before I was born: literally "from my mother's womb," echoing the calls of the prophets (Isa 49:1; Jer 1:5).
- l (1:16) Gentiles: Greek *ethnē*, "nations," the non-Jewish peoples.

- m (1:16) Any human being: literally “flesh and blood.”
- n (1:17) Arabia: probably the Nabatean kingdom, which lay south and east of Damascus and extended into the Sinai (compare 4:25).
- o (1:18) *Cephas*: Aramaic *Kepha*, “rock,” the name Jesus gave to Simon; its Greek equivalent is *Peter* (John 1:42).
- p (1:19) *James*: the English form of Greek *Iakōbos*, that is, *Jacob* (“heel-grabber” or “he supplants,” Gen 25:26). This James led the Jerusalem church (Acts 15:13; 21:18). The Greek can also be read, “I saw no other apostle, only James.”
- q (1:21) Cilicia: the region on the southeast coast of Asia Minor, whose chief city was Tarsus, Paul’s birthplace (Acts 22:3).

Chapter 2

1 Then after fourteen years[a] I went up again to Jerusalem with Barnabas,[b] taking Titus[c] along also. 2 I went up because of a revelation,
and I laid before them the gospel that I proclaim among the Gentiles.
I did so privately before those who were held in high esteem, for
fear that I might be running, or had run, in vain. 3 Yet Titus, my
companion, though a Greek, was not forced to undergo circumcision.
4 The pressure came from false brothers who had been smuggled in,
men who crept in to spy out the freedom that is ours in Christ Jesus,
intending to enslave us.[d] 5 We did not give in to them by submitting
even for a moment,[e] so that the truth of the gospel might remain with
you. 6 And from those who were held in esteem (whatever they once
were makes no difference to me; God shows no partiality)[f] — those
esteemed men added nothing to my message. 7 Quite the reverse:
they saw that the gospel for the uncircumcised had been put into my
hands, as the gospel for the circumcised had been put into Peter’s.[g]
8 For God, who empowered Peter for his mission as apostle to the
circumcised, empowered me as well for mine to the Gentiles. 9 James,
Cephas, and John,[h] who were reputed to be pillars, acknowledged
the grace granted to me, and they gave Barnabas and me their right
hands in partnership: we were to go to the Gentiles, and they to the
circumcised. 10 Their one request was that we keep the poor in mind,
and that was the very thing I had made it my concern to do.
11 But when Cephas came to Antioch,[i] I opposed him to his face, be-
cause he stood condemned. 12 Until certain people arrived from James,
he had been eating with Gentiles; but once they came he started to

withdraw and hold himself aloof, fearing the advocates of circumcision. 13 The rest of the Jews joined him in this pretense,[j] so that even Barnabas was carried away by their pretense. 14 I saw that they were not walking straight with the truth of the gospel, and I said to Cephas before everyone, "You are a Jew, yet you live in Gentile fashion and not in Jewish fashion. How then can you force the Gentiles to adopt Jewish ways?"

15 We are Jews by nature, not sinners of Gentile stock, 16 but we know that no one is put right with God[k] by works of the law, only through faith in Jesus Christ.[l] And so we ourselves came to believe in Christ Jesus, so as to be put right by faith in Christ and not by works of the law; for by works of the law no human being[m] will be put right. 17 But if, while we seek to be justified in Christ, we ourselves are also found to be sinners, does that make Christ a servant of sin? Certainly not! 18 For if I rebuild what I once tore down, I prove that I am a lawbreaker. 19 Through the law I have died to the law, in order to live to God. With Christ I have been crucified.[n] 20 I no longer live; Christ lives in me. The life I live now in this body,[o] I live through trusting the Son of God, who loved me and surrendered himself for my sake. 21 I do not set aside the grace of God; for if righteousness came through the law, then Christ died for nothing.

Notes

- a (2:1) After fourteen years: counted either from his conversion or from the visit of 1:18.
- b (2:1) *Barnabas*: interpreted in Acts 4:36 as "son of encouragement"; the derivation is uncertain.
- c (2:1) *Titus*: a Latin name of uncertain meaning; he was a Gentile coworker of Paul (2 Cor 8:23; Titus 1:4).
- d (2:4) The Greek sentence of verses 4–5 is broken off and does not complete its grammar; the opening words have been supplied to make the sense clear.
- e (2:5) A moment: literally "an hour," an idiom for a brief time. A few Western witnesses lack "to them, not even," which reverses the sense ("we gave in for a moment"); the earliest manuscripts, including P46, have the negative.
- f (2:6) Shows no partiality: literally "does not receive the face of a person," a Hebrew idiom for judging by appearances.
- g (2:7) *Peter*: Greek *Petros*, "rock," the Greek equivalent of *Cephas* (1:18).
- h (2:9) *John*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yohanan*, "Yahweh has been gracious."

- i (2:11) Antioch: Antioch in Syria, on the Orontes River, the third city of the Roman Empire and a center of the early Gentile mission (Acts 11:19–26).
- j (2:13) Pretense: Greek *hypokrisis*, "play-acting," traditionally "hypocrisy."
- k (2:16) Put right with God: traditionally "justified"; Greek *dikaioō*, to declare or put in the right before God; related to *dikaiosynē*, "righteousness."
- l (2:16) Faith in Jesus Christ: Greek *pistis Iēsou Christou*, which may also be translated "the faithfulness of Jesus Christ"; so also later in the verse, in 2:20 and 3:22. Scholars are divided.
- m (2:16) No human being: literally "all flesh shall not," echoing Ps 143:2 (142:2 in the Greek Old Testament).
- n (2:19) In the Greek text, "I have been crucified with Christ" begins verse 20.
- o (2:20) In the body: literally "in the flesh."

Chapter 3

1 Senseless Galatians! Who has put you under a spell, you before
whose eyes Jesus Christ was publicly displayed on the cross?[a] 2 I
only want to find out one thing from you: was it by keeping the
law that you received the Spirit, or by believing what you heard?[b] 3
Can you be that senseless? You started out with the Spirit; are you
now completing it through human effort?[c] 4 Have you experienced so
much to no purpose? If it really was to no purpose.[d] 5 When God gives
you the Spirit and works deeds of power among you, is it because
you do works of the law, or because you heard and believed?
6 It was the same with Abraham: "He believed God, and it was
counted to him as righteousness."[e] 7 You see, then, that the people of
faith are the real children[f] of Abraham. 8 The Scripture saw ahead
that God would put the nations right through faith, and announced
the good news to Abraham in advance: "All nations will be blessed
through you."[g] 9 Accordingly the people of faith share the blessing
with Abraham, who had faith.
10 All who depend on works of the law live under a curse, for it stands
written, "A curse is on everyone who does not abide by all that is
written in the book of the law, to do it."[h] 11 That no one is put right
with God by the law is clear, because "By faith the righteous one will
live."[i] 12 But the law does not rest on faith; on the contrary, "The one
who does them will live by them."[j] 13 Christ redeemed us from the
curse of the law by becoming a curse for us, for it is written, "Cursed

is everyone who is hung on a tree."[k] 14 This was so that the blessing of
Abraham might reach the Gentiles in Christ Jesus, and that through
faith we might receive the Spirit who was promised.
15 Friends, I will use an everyday illustration:[l] even a person's will,
once it is validated, cannot be canceled or amended by anyone else. 16
The promises were spoken to Abraham and to his offspring. Scripture
does not say "offsprings," referring to many, but speaks of one: "and
to your offspring,"[m] that is, Christ. 17 My point is this: a covenant that
God had already ratified is not annulled by the law, which came into
being four hundred and thirty years afterward,[n] so as to make the
promise void. 18 If the inheritance depended on the law, it would no
longer depend on a promise; yet it was by a promise that God freely
granted it to Abraham.
19 What, then, was the law for? It was added to deal with offenses,[o]
until the descendant to whom the promise was made would arrive; it
was ordained through angels, by means of an intermediary.[p] 20 A go-
between does not act for one party alone; but God is one.[q]
21 Does this set the law against the promises of God? By no means! If a
law had been given that was able to make alive, righteousness would
truly have been by the law. 22 But Scripture has locked up everything
under the power of sin, so that what was promised might be given,
by faith in Jesus Christ, to those who believe.
23 Until faith came, we were kept under guard by the law, confined
until the coming faith should be revealed. 24 So the law became our
guardian[r] until Christ came, so that we might be justified by faith. 25
But now that faith has come, we are no longer under a guardian. 26 For
in Christ Jesus you are all children of God through faith. 27 All of you
who were baptized into Christ have put on Christ like a garment. 28
Gone are the distinctions of Jew and Greek, slave and free, male and
female;[s] all of you are one in Christ Jesus. 29 If you are Christ's, you
are Abraham's offspring, and heirs as the promise said.

Notes

- a (3:1) Publicly displayed: Greek *prographō*, to placard or post a public notice. Later manuscripts add "that you should not obey the truth" and "among you."

- b (3:2) Hearing with faith: or “the message of faith”; Greek *akoē* means both “hearing” and “what is heard”; also in verse 5.
- c (3:3) The flesh: Greek *sarx*, here human nature apart from God, and perhaps also a pointed allusion to circumcision.
- d (3:4) Experienced: or “suffered”; the Greek verb *paschō* can be used of good experiences as well as of suffering.
- e (3:6) Gen 15:6, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament. *Abraham* means “father of a multitude” (Gen 17:5).
- f (3:7) Children: literally “sons”; so also in 3:26 and 4:6–7, where it carries the legal sense of heirs.
- g (3:8) Gen 12:3, combined with Gen 18:18. *Nations* and *Gentiles* translate the same Greek word, *ethnē*.
- h (3:10) Deut 27:26, quoted freely from the Greek Old Testament, with wording drawn from Deut 28:58.
- i (3:11) Hab 2:4. The Hebrew reads “by his faithfulness”; the Greek Old Testament reads “by my faithfulness.” The Greek can also be read “The one who is righteous by faith will live.”
- j (3:12) Lev 18:5. In the Hebrew text it is introduced by “I am Yahweh.”
- k (3:13) Deut 21:23, quoted freely. *Tree*: Greek *xylon*, “wood,” also used of the cross (Acts 5:30).
- l (3:15) Literally “I speak according to man.”
- m (3:16) Offspring: literally “seed,” a collective noun in Hebrew and Greek. The promise is found in Gen 12:7; 13:15; 17:8; 24:7.
- n (3:17) Four hundred and thirty years: compare Exod 12:40, where the Greek Old Testament and the Samaritan Pentateuch count this period as including the time in Canaan as well as Egypt; the Hebrew counts it for Egypt alone.
- o (3:19) Because of transgressions: either to restrain them, or to expose them and define them as such (compare Rom 4:15; 5:20).
- p (3:19) Through angels: a Jewish tradition held that angels took part in giving the law at Sinai (Deut 33:2 in the Greek Old Testament; Acts 7:53; Heb 2:2). *Mediator*: Moses.
- q (3:20) This verse is notoriously difficult and has been interpreted in hundreds of ways. Its point may be that the law came indirectly, through intermediaries, while the promise came directly from the one God.
- r (3:24) Guardian: Greek *paidagōgos*, a household slave who escorted a boy to school and supervised his conduct until he came of age; not a teacher.
- s (3:28) Male and female: the wording echoes Gen 1:27 in the Greek Old Testament; note the change from “nor” to “and.”

Chapter 4

[1] I mean this: so long as the heir is under age, he is no better off than a slave, even though all the property is his. [2] Guardians and stewards

have charge of him until the time his father has fixed. 3 So with us
also: when we were minors, we were enslaved under the elemental
forces of the world.[a] 4 But when the full time had arrived, God sent
out his Son, born of a woman, born subject to the law, 5 so that he
might buy freedom for those subject to the law, and that we might
be adopted as children.[b] 6 And because you are children, God has sent
the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, "Abba! Father!"[c] 7 You are
therefore no longer a slave but a son, and since you are a son, God
has also made you an heir.[d]
8 In the past, not knowing God, you served as slaves those who
by nature are not gods. 9 But now you know God, or rather God
knows you. How can you go back again to those feeble and beggarly
elemental forces, and long to be their slaves once more? 10 You are
observing special days and months and seasons and years! 11 I fear for
you, that I may have labored over you in vain.
12 Brothers, I beg you, become as I am, because I also have become as
you are. You did me no wrong. 13 As you know, it was an illness of the
body[e] that first gave me the occasion to preach the gospel to you, 14
and although my condition put you to the test,[f] you neither scorned
nor spurned me;[g] instead you made me welcome as though I were
an angel of God, even as though I were Christ Jesus. 15 Where then is
your sense of blessing? For I can testify that, if it had been possible,
you would have torn out your eyes and given them to me. 16 Have I
then become your enemy by telling you the truth? 17 Those people are
eager to win you over, but with bad intentions. They would like to
isolate you, so that you will be eager to follow them. 18 It is good to
be courted for a good purpose at all times, and not only when I am
present with you. 19 My little children, I am once again in labor pains
for you, until Christ takes shape in you. 20 I wish I could be present
with you now and change my tone, because I am at a loss about you.
21 Tell me, you who want to be under the law, do you not listen to
the law?
22 For it is written that Abraham had two sons, one by the slave woman
and one by the free woman.[h]

23 But the son of the slave woman was born according to the flesh, and
the son of the free woman through the promise.
24 This is an allegory:[i] the two women stand for two covenants.
One comes from Mount Sinai and bears children into slavery; that
is Hagar.[j]
25 Hagar stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia;[k] she matches the Jerusalem
of today, which is enslaved along with her children.
26 The Jerusalem that is above, though, is free, and that city is our
mother.
27 Scripture says,

> "Be glad, you barren one who never gave birth;
> burst into song and cry aloud, you who never felt labor pains;
> for many more are the children of the forsaken one
> than of the one who has a husband."[l]

28 Now you, brothers, like Isaac, are children of the promise.[m]
29 Yet just as then the child born by natural descent harassed the child
born through the Spirit, so it is today.
30 But what does Scripture say? "Drive out the slave woman and her
son, for the son of the slave woman shall never share the inheritance
with the son of the free woman."[n]
31 So, brothers, we are not the slave woman's children but the free
woman's.

Notes

- a (4:3) Elemental forces: Greek *stoicheia*, "basic elements," meaning either the elementary principles of religion, or the physical elements and the spiritual powers thought to rule them; also in verse 9.
- b (4:5) Adopted as children: Greek *huiothesia*, the legal adoption of a son, which gave him full rights as heir.
- c (4:6) *Abba*: Aramaic for "father," the word Jesus used in prayer (Mark 14:36); Paul gives the Greek translation after it.
- d (4:7) God has also made you an heir: literally "an heir through God"; later manuscripts read "an heir of God through Christ."
- e (4:13) An illness of the body: literally "a weakness of the flesh." Its nature is unknown; verse 15 has suggested to some an eye disease.
- f (4:14) My condition put you to the test: literally "your trial in my flesh," so the earliest manuscripts; later ones read "my trial that was in my flesh."

- g (4:14) Spurned: literally “spit out,” perhaps alluding to the ancient practice of spitting to ward off evil from someone sick.
- h (4:22) Gen 16:15; 21:2. The slave woman is Hagar, the free woman Sarah.
- i (4:24) Taken figuratively: Greek *allēgoroumena*, “spoken as an allegory.”
- j (4:24) *Hagar*: perhaps related to Arabic *hajara*, “to flee” or “to emigrate”; the meaning is uncertain.
- k (4:25) Hagar stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia: literally “Now Hagar is Mount Sinai in Arabia,” so the Westcott–Hort text. Some manuscripts, including Sinaiticus, read “For Sinai is a mountain in Arabia.” Paul may be playing on an Arabic word for rock or mountain that sounded like *Hagar*; this is uncertain.
- l (4:27) Isa 54:1, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- m (4:28) *Isaac*: Hebrew *Yitsḥaq*, “he laughs” (Gen 21:6). Some manuscripts read “we … are.”
- n (4:30) Gen 21:10, where Sarah says “with my son Isaac.”

Chapter 5

1 Christ freed us so that we might be free. So stand your ground, and
do not let yourselves be held once more under a slave’s yoke.
2 Take note: I, Paul, say to you plainly that Christ will be of no use
to you at all if you let yourselves be circumcised. 3 I declare again to
every man who accepts circumcision that he is bound to carry out the
entire law. 4 You who look to the law to put you right with God have
been severed from Christ; you have dropped out of grace. 5 But we,
by the Spirit and through faith, wait eagerly for the righteousness we
hope for. 6 For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision counts for anything; what counts is faith working through love.
7 You were running a good race. Who blocked your way and kept you
from obeying the truth? 8 Such persuading does not come from him
who calls you. 9 It takes only a little yeast to work through all the
dough. 10 I am confident in the Lord about you that you will take no
other view. But the one who is unsettling you will bear the penalty,
whoever he may be. 11 But if I, brothers, am still preaching circumcision, why am I still being persecuted? In that case the stumbling block
of the cross has been removed. 12 I wish those who are disturbing you
would go so far as to castrate themselves![a]
13 Brothers, you were called to be free. But do not let freedom become a
foothold for the flesh; instead, be slaves to one another through love.

14 For the whole law is summed up in a single command: “You shall
love your neighbor as yourself.”[b] 15 If you go on biting and tearing at
one another, watch out, or you will be eaten up by one another.
16 This is what I say: let the Spirit direct your steps, and you will never
satisfy the cravings of the flesh. 17 What the flesh craves is contrary
to the Spirit, and what the Spirit desires is contrary to the flesh; the
two are at war with each other, to keep you from doing whatever
you wish. 18 But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the
law. 19 Now the works of the flesh are plain: sexual immorality, impu-
rity, indecency, 20 idolatry, sorcery,[c] hatreds, strife, jealousy, fits of
rage, selfish rivalries, divisions, factions, 21 jealousy,[d] drinking parties,
orgies, and similar things. I warn you, as I warned you earlier, that
those who practice such things will not inherit God’s kingdom. 22 But
the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness,
faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control. Against such things there is
no law. 24 And those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the
flesh with its passions and desires.
25 Since the Spirit gives us life, let the Spirit also order our steps. 26 Let
us not become conceited, provoking one another and envying one
another.

Notes

- a (5:12) Castrate themselves: Greek *apokoptō*, “cut off,” a bitter play on circumcision, perhaps alluding to the self-castration practiced by priests of the goddess Cybele in Galatia.
- b (5:14) Lev 19:18.
- c (5:20) Sorcery: Greek *pharmakeia*, the use of drugs and potions in magic.
- d (5:21) Envy: later manuscripts add “murders.”

Chapter 6

1 Brothers, if someone is caught in any wrongdoing, you who are
spiritual should restore such a person in a spirit of gentleness. Watch
yourself, so that you also are not tempted. 2 Carry one another’s
burdens, and in this way fulfill the law of Christ.[a] 3 Anyone who
imagines he is something, when he is nothing, is fooling himself. 4 Let
each one examine his own work, and then his reason for pride will

be in himself alone, and not in comparison with someone else. 5 For each will carry his own load.[b]
6 Whoever is being instructed in the word should share every good thing with his instructor. 7 Do not be deceived: God is not mocked. Whatever a person sows, that he will also reap. 8 Sow to please your own flesh, and from the flesh you will reap ruin; sow to please the Spirit, and from the Spirit you will reap eternal life. 9 We must not tire of doing what is right, for when the time comes we shall reap, if we do not lose heart. 10 Therefore, whenever we get the chance, let us work for the good of all, above all for those in the family of believers.
11 Notice how large the letters are as I now write to you in my own hand![c] 12 Those who want to make a good showing in the flesh are the ones who are trying to compel you to be circumcised, only so that they may not be persecuted for the cross of Christ. 13 Even those who are circumcised do not keep the law themselves; they want you circumcised so that they can boast of your flesh. 14 But as for me, may I never boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, through which[d] the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world. 15 For neither circumcision nor uncircumcision is anything; what matters is a new creation. 16 And for all who will follow this rule, peace be upon them, and mercy, and upon the Israel of God.[e]
17 For the rest, let no one make trouble for me, because I carry the marks of Jesus branded on my body.[f]
18 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit, brothers. Amen.

Notes

- a (6:2) Fulfill: the Westcott–Hort text has the command; other manuscripts, among them Vaticanus as reported, read "you will fulfill."
- b (6:5) Load: Greek *phortion*, a person's own pack, distinct from the heavy "burdens" (*barē*) of verse 2.
- c (6:11) In my own hand: Paul usually dictated his letters to a scribe (Rom 16:22) and added a closing in his own handwriting (1 Cor 16:21; 2 Thess 3:17).
- d (6:14) Through which: or "through whom."
- e (6:16) And upon the Israel of God: or "that is, upon the Israel of God." The phrase may refer to the church of Jews and Gentiles together, or to Jewish believers, or

to the Jewish people as a whole. Compare the Jewish benediction “Peace be upon Israel” (Ps 125:5; 128:6).

- f (6:17) Marks: Greek *stigmata*, brands such as were put on slaves to show who owned them; here the scars of Paul’s sufferings for Jesus (2 Cor 11:23–25).

Ephesians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] an apostle[b] of Christ Jesus[c] by God's will, to the holy ones who
are in Ephesus,[d] who are also faithful in Christ Jesus: 2 grace be yours,
and peace, from God our Father and from the Lord Jesus Christ.
3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who in Christ
has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly realms.[e] 4
For he chose us in him before the world was founded, that we should
be holy and without blemish in his presence. In love[f] 5 he marked us
out beforehand to be adopted as his children through Jesus Christ,
in keeping with the good pleasure of his will, 6 so that the glory of
his grace might be praised, the grace he has freely given us in the
one he loves.[g] 7 In him, through his blood, we have redemption, the
forgiveness of our wrongdoings, as rich as his grace is rich, 8 that
grace he has poured out on us in full measure, with all wisdom and
insight. 9 He has made known to us the secret of his will,[h] according to
the good purpose that he set forth in Christ, 10 a plan for the fullness of
the times:[i] to bring all things together under one head in Christ, the
things in heaven and the things on earth. 11 In him we also were made
God's portion,[j] having been marked out beforehand by the purpose
of the one who works out everything as his will determines, 12 in order
that we, who were first to place our hope in Christ, might bring praise
to his glory. 13 In him you also, after hearing the true message, the
gospel[k] that saves you, and believing in him, received the promised
Holy Spirit as your seal.[l] 14 The Spirit is the down payment[m] on our
inheritance, until God redeems those who are his own possession, to
the praise of his glory.
15 That is why I too, since I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus and
your regard for all the holy ones,[n] 16 never stop giving thanks for you
as I mention you in my prayers. 17 My prayer is that the God of our

Lord Jesus Christ, the glorious Father, will give you a spirit of wisdom and insight as you get to know him, 18 the eyes of your heart having been filled with light, so that you may know what hope his calling holds, what wealth of glory is in his inheritance among the holy ones, 19 and how surpassingly great his power is toward us who believe. It is the same mighty strength at work 20 that he put to work in Christ when he raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand[o] in the heavenly realms, 21 far above all rule, authority, power, and lordship,[p] and every title that can be given, not only in the present age but in the coming one. 22 God has placed everything beneath his feet,[q] and made him head over everything for the sake of the church. 23 The church is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.[r]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, "one who is sent," a messenger with the authority of the sender.
- c (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah."
- d (1:1) In Ephesus: these words are absent from the earliest manuscripts, P46 (about AD 200) and the original hands of Sinaiticus and Vaticanus (4th century), and from the text known to Origen; Westcott and Hort print them in brackets. Without them the Greek reads awkwardly, "to the holy ones who are, and faithful in Christ Jesus," and the letter may have been a circular with a space for the name of each church. In the second century Marcion knew it as the letter "to the Laodiceans" (compare Col 4:16). *Ephesus*, a port on the west coast of Asia Minor, was the capital of the Roman province of Asia, where Paul worked for over two years (Acts 19:1–20).
- e (1:3) In the heavenly realms: Greek *en tois epouraniois*, "among the heavenly things," a phrase found only in this letter (also 1:20; 2:6; 3:10; 6:12). Verses 3–14 are a single sentence in Greek.
- f (1:4) In love: these words may go either with what precedes ("without blemish before him in love") or, as here, with verse 5.
- g (1:6) The one he loves: literally "the Beloved," a title for Christ.
- h (1:9) Secret: Greek *mystērion*, traditionally "mystery," not a puzzle but God's purpose once hidden and now disclosed; so throughout the letter.
- i (1:10) Plan: Greek *oikonomia*, "household management," the arrangement by which God carries out his purpose; also in 3:2, 9.

- j (1:11) Were made God's portion: or "obtained an inheritance." The Greek verb *klēroō* means to be chosen by lot or allotted, as Israel was the Lord's allotted portion (Deut 32:9).
- k (1:13) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally "gospel"; so throughout.
- l (1:13) Sealed: a seal marked ownership and guaranteed that something was genuine and protected.
- m (1:14) Down payment: Greek *arrabōn*, a deposit or first installment that guarantees the full amount will follow.
- n (1:15) Your regard for: literally simply "your [faith] toward"; the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, the original hands of Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus, and Vaticanus, lacks the word "love," which most later manuscripts include ("your love toward all the holy ones"), probably from Col 1:4.
- o (1:20) At his right hand: an echo of Ps 110:1 (109:1 in the Greek Old Testament), the place of highest honor and authority.
- p (1:21) Ruler … dominion: terms for ranks of spiritual powers, as in Col 1:16.
- q (1:22) Ps 8:6 (8:7 in Hebrew).
- r (1:23) Who fills all in all: or "who is being filled, all in all." The Greek participle can be middle or passive, and the meaning of the whole phrase is much discussed.

Chapter 2

1 As for you, you were dead through your wrongdoings and sins, 2 in
which you once lived your lives,[a] following the course of this world,
following the ruler of the domain of the air, the spirit that is now at
work in the children of disobedience.[b] 3 Among them all of us also
once lived, in the cravings of our flesh, doing what the flesh and its
impulses willed, and we were by nature children of wrath, as the
rest of humankind were. 4 But God is rich in mercy, and because of
the great love he had for us, 5 even when we were dead through our
wrongdoings, made us alive together with Christ (it is by grace you
have been saved), 6 and raised us up with him and seated us with him
in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus, 7 so that in the ages to come
he might display the overflowing riches of his grace in his kindness
toward us in Christ Jesus. 8 It is by grace that you are saved, through
faith. Nor does this come from you: it is God's gift,[c] 9 and not earned
by works, so that no one may boast. 10 We are his handiwork,[d] created
in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared in advance as
the path for our lives.

11 Keep in mind, then, that you were once Gentiles by birth,[e] people
whom those calling themselves “the circumcision” (a circumcision
done in the flesh by hand) called “the uncircumcision.” 12 Remember
that at that time you were without Christ, cut off from the common-
wealth of Israel and strangers to the covenants of promise, with no
hope and without God in the world. 13 But now, in Christ Jesus, you
who were once far away have come near through Christ’s blood. 14
For he is our peace. He made the two groups one and broke down the
dividing wall that kept them apart,[f] 15 the hostility, by setting aside
in his flesh the law with its commandments and regulations, so that
in himself he might create one new humanity[g] out of the two, so
making peace, 16 and that through the cross he might reconcile both
of them to God in a single body, killing the hostility by it.[h] 17 And
he came and proclaimed peace to you who were far off and peace to
those who were near,[i] 18 for through him we both have access in one
Spirit to the Father. 19 Consequently you are no longer strangers and
outsiders; you are fellow citizens with God’s people and belong to
God’s household, 20 You stand built upon the foundation laid by the
apostles and prophets, and its cornerstone is Christ Jesus himself.[j] 21
In him the whole building is joined together and grows into a holy
temple in the Lord. 22 and in him you too are being built up together
to become a place where God lives by the Spirit.

Notes

- a (2:2) Lived your lives: literally “walked,” a Hebrew idiom for one’s conduct; so throughout the letter.
- b (2:2) Children of disobedience: literally “sons of disobedience,” a Hebrew idiom for people marked by disobedience; also in 5:6.
- c (2:8) This … God’s gift: the Greek pronoun “this” is neuter and refers to the whole event of salvation by grace through faith, not to “faith” alone (a feminine noun).
- d (2:10) Handiwork: Greek *poiēma*, “something made,” a work of craftsmanship or art.
- e (2:11) Gentiles: Greek *ethnē*, “nations,” the non-Jewish peoples; so throughout.
- f (2:14) Dividing wall: perhaps an allusion to the barrier in the Jerusalem temple that kept Gentiles out of the inner courts on pain of death, a stone warning from which survives.
- g (2:15) Humanity: literally “man” (Greek *anthrōpos*, “human being”); also in 4:13, 22, 24.

- h (2:16) By it: that is, by the cross; or “in himself.”
- i (2:17) Isa 57:19; compare Isa 52:7.
- j (2:20) Cornerstone: Greek *akrogōniaios*, the stone that sets the line of a building (Isa 28:16 in the Greek Old Testament); some understand it as the capstone at the top of an arch.

Chapter 3

1 This is why I, Paul, am a prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you
Gentiles[a] — 2 assuming that you have heard how God entrusted me
with the stewardship[b] of his grace for your benefit: 3 the secret was
disclosed to me by a revelation, as I wrote in brief a little earlier.[c] 4
When you read this, you will be able to perceive my understanding of
the secret of Christ. 5 This was not disclosed to people[d] in earlier ages
as it has now been uncovered by the Spirit to his holy apostles and
prophets: 6 through the gospel the Gentiles are co-heirs with Israel,
parts of one body, and partners in the promise in Christ Jesus. 7 I
was made a minister[e] of this gospel through the gift of God’s grace,
which was granted to me by the exercise of his power. 8 Though I
am less than the least of all God’s people, I was given this privilege:
to announce to the nations the boundless wealth of Christ, 9 and to
bring to light what the plan of the secret is,[f] which for ages past was
hidden in God who created all things, 10 so that through the church
the manifold wisdom of God might now be made known to the rulers
and authorities in the heavenly realms. 11 This was according to the
eternal purpose[g] that he carried out in Christ Jesus our Lord, 12 in
whom we have boldness and confident access to God through faith
in him.[h] 13 I ask you, therefore, not to be discouraged by my afflictions
on your behalf, for they are your glory.
14 For this reason I kneel before the Father,[i] 15 from whom every family[j]
in heaven and on earth takes its name. 16 I pray that from the wealth
of his glory he may give you strength, and make you mighty through
his Spirit in the inner person, 17 so that Christ may make his home in
your hearts through faith; and that you, rooted and founded firmly
in love, 18 will be strong enough to comprehend, along with all God’s
people, how wide, how long, how high, and how deep[k] 19 is the love

of Christ that surpasses understanding, and so be filled with all the fullness of God.

20 To the one who can accomplish immeasurably more than anything we ask or think, through the power operating within us, 21 to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus through every generation, forever and ever. Amen.

Notes

- a (3:1) Paul breaks off his sentence here and takes it up again in verse 14.
- b (3:2) Stewardship: the same Greek word, *oikonomia*, as "plan" in 1:10 and 3:9.
- c (3:3) A little earlier: probably referring to 1:9–10 and 2:11–22.
- d (3:5) Humankind: literally "the sons of men."
- e (3:7) Servant: Greek *diakonos*, "servant" or "minister," one who serves on another's behalf.
- f (3:9) To bring to light: many manuscripts add "for all people" ("to make all people see"); the Westcott–Hort text, with the original hand of Sinaiticus and with Alexandrinus, lacks it.
- g (3:11) Eternal purpose: literally "purpose of the ages."
- h (3:12) Faith in him: or "his faithfulness."
- i (3:14) The Father: later manuscripts add "of our Lord Jesus Christ."
- j (3:15) Family: Greek *patria*, a family or clan descended from one father, a wordplay on *patēr*, "father."
- k (3:18) Breadth … depth: the object is not stated; probably the love of Christ (verse 19), or the whole scope of God's purpose.

Chapter 4

1 As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I appeal to you to lead a life that is worthy of the call you have received, 2 Be humble in every way and gentle; be patient, putting up with one another in love, 3 doing all you can to preserve the unity that the Spirit gives, through the peace that ties you together. 4 There is one body and one Spirit, as there is one hope to which you were called; 5 one Lord, one faith, one baptism; 6 one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all.

7 But to each one of us grace was given according to the measure of Christ's gift.

8 That is why it says, "When he went up on high he led captives away,
and he gave gifts to people."[a]

9 (Now what does “he went up” mean, except that he had also gone
down into the lower regions, the earth?[b]
10 The one who went down is the same one who also went up far above
all the heavens, so that he might fill all things.)
11 And he is the one who gave certain people to be apostles, others
prophets, others evangelists, and others pastors and teachers,[c]
12 to equip the holy ones for the work of service, for the building up
of the body of Christ,
13 until all of us arrive at the unity of the faith and of the knowledge
of the Son of God, at mature adulthood, at the measure of the stature[d]
of the fullness of Christ.
14 Then we will no longer be infants, tossed about by the waves
and swept around by every wind of teaching, by human trickery, by
craftiness in deceitful scheming.[e]
15 Rather, as we speak the truth in love, we are to grow in all respects
into Christ, who is the head.
16 from whom the whole body, joined and knit together by every
supporting ligament, grows as each part does its work, and builds
itself up in love.
17 This then I tell you, and I insist on it in the Lord: do not go
on living like the Gentiles, whose minds are set on empty things. 18
Their understanding is darkened, and they are estranged from the
life of God because of the ignorance that is in them, because their
hearts have grown hard. 19 They have become callous and have given
themselves over to indecency, to practice every kind of impurity with
greed. 20 But you did not learn Christ that way — 21 if indeed you have
heard of him and were taught in him, as the truth is in Jesus: 22 that
you were to put away your former way of life, the old self[f] that is
being ruined by its deceitful desires, 23 and to be made new in the spirit
of your minds, 24 and to clothe yourselves with the new self, which
has been created after God’s likeness[g] in righteousness and holiness
that come from the truth.
25 So, putting away falsehood, let each of you speak the truth with
his neighbor,[h] for we are members of one another. 26 “Be angry, yet
do not sin.”[i] Let the sun not set while you are still angry, 27 and do

not give the devil[j] a foothold. 28 The thief must no longer steal; rather
he must work hard, doing what is good with his own hands, so that
he may have something to share with anyone in need. 29 Let no foul
language leave your lips, only what is useful for building others up
as the occasion demands, so that your words will bring grace to
those who listen. 30 And do not bring grief to God's Holy Spirit, with
whom you have been sealed for the day when you will be redeemed.[k]
31 Let all bitterness and rage and anger and shouting and slander be
removed from you, along with all malice. 32 Be kind to one another,
tenderhearted, forgiving one another, just as God in Christ forgave
you.[l]

Notes

- a (4:8) Ps 68:18 (68:19 in Hebrew; 67:19 in the Greek Old Testament), where the Hebrew and the Greek read "you received gifts among people." The reading "gave" agrees with an interpretation also found in the Aramaic Targum of the Psalms, which applies the verse to Moses giving the law.
- b (4:9) The lower regions, the earth: or "the regions lower than the earth," that is, the realm of the dead. The Greek may mean either the earth itself (the incarnation) or the underworld. Later manuscripts add "first" after "gone down."
- c (4:11) Pastors: Greek *poimenes*, "shepherds." The Greek groups "pastors and teachers" together, perhaps as one ministry.
- d (4:13) Stature: or "age"; Greek *hēlikia* can mean either.
- e (4:14) Trickery: Greek *kybeia*, "dice-playing," cheating.
- f (4:22) Self: literally "man" (Greek *anthrōpos*); also in verse 24.
- g (4:24) After God's likeness: literally "according to God."
- h (4:25) Zech 8:16.
- i (4:26) Ps 4:4 (4:5 in Hebrew), in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- j (4:27) Devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer."
- k (4:30) Compare Isa 63:10.
- l (4:32) You: some manuscripts read "us."

Chapter 5

1 So be imitators of God, as dearly loved children,
2 and live in love, just as Christ loved you[a] and gave himself up for
you as an offering and a sacrifice to God, a fragrant aroma.[b]
3 As is fitting among holy people, sexual immorality, any kind of
impurity, or greed should not so much as be mentioned among you.

4 Shameful conduct, silly talk, and coarse jesting are not fitting either;
let there be thanksgiving instead.
5 Of this you may be quite certain: no one who is sexually immoral,
impure, or greedy (for greed is idolatry) has a share in the kingdom
of Christ and of God.
6 Let no one deceive you with empty words, for because of these
things the wrath of God comes on the children of disobedience.
7 So do not become partners with them.
8 There was a time when you were darkness; now, in the Lord, you
are light. Conduct yourselves as children of the light,
9 since what the light produces[c] is every kind of goodness, righteous-
ness, and truth.
10 Test and discover what pleases the Lord.
11 Take no part in the fruitless works of darkness; instead, expose
them.
12 For it is shameful even to speak of the things they do in secret.
13 But everything exposed by the light becomes visible,
14 for everything that becomes visible is light. That is why it says,
"Wake up, sleeper,
and rise from the dead,
and Christ will shine on you."[d]
15 Take great care, then, how you conduct yourselves, as wise people
and not as fools, 16 making the most of the time,[e] because the days
are evil. 17 So do not be foolish, but understand what the will of the
Lord is. 18 Do not be drunk on wine, for that is the way of ruin;[f] let the
Spirit fill you instead, 19 speaking to one another in psalms and hymns
and spiritual songs, singing and making music to the Lord with your
heart, 20 giving thanks at all times and for all things to God the Father,
in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ; 21 and be subject to one another
in the fear of Christ.[g]
22 Wives, submit to your own husbands as to the Lord.[h] 23 For the
husband is head of the wife as Christ also is head of the church; he
himself is the Savior of the body. 24 Just as the church is subject to
Christ, wives should also be subject to their husbands in all things. 25
Husbands, love your wives in the way that Christ loved the church

and offered himself on her behalf, [26] so that he might make her holy,
cleansing her by the washing of water with the word, [27] so that he
might present the church to himself glorious, with no stain or wrinkle
or any such flaw, holy and without blemish. [28] So husbands too are
bound to love their wives as they love their own bodies; to love one's
wife is to love oneself. [29] For no one ever hated his own body,[i] but he
nourishes it and cares for it, just as Christ does the church, [30] because
we are members of his body.[j] [31] "For this reason a man will leave his
father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become
one flesh."[k] [32] There is a great secret here, and I take it to refer to Christ
and the church. [33] However, each one of you must also love his wife
as himself, and the wife must see that she respects her husband.[l]

Notes

- a (5:2) You: some manuscripts read "us," here and later in the verse.
- b (5:2) A fragrant aroma: literally "an odor of fragrance," the Greek Old Testament phrase for a sacrifice acceptable to God (Gen 8:21; Exod 29:18).
- c (5:9) The light: later manuscripts read "the Spirit," from Gal 5:22.
- d (5:14) Not a quotation of any known Old Testament text; probably an early Christian hymn, perhaps sung at baptism, drawing on Isa 26:19; 60:1. In the Greek text the first half of verse 14 ("for everything … is light") completes verse 13.
- e (5:16) Making the most of the time: literally "buying up the opportunity."
- f (5:18) The way of ruin: Greek *asōtia*, dissipation, a wasted and unrestrained life (compare Luke 15:13).
- g (5:21) Verse 21 completes the sentence that begins in verse 18, and at the same time heads the instructions to the household that follow (5:22–6:9).
- h (5:22) Wives, submit: the Greek of the earliest manuscript, P46, and of Vaticanus has no verb here and takes it from verse 21 ("submitting … wives to your husbands"). Other manuscripts supply "let them submit" or "submit."
- i (5:29) Body: literally "flesh."
- j (5:30) Later manuscripts add "of his flesh and of his bones," from Gen 2:23; the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, lacks it.
- k (5:31) Gen 2:24, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament.
- l (5:33) Respects: literally "fears," in the sense of reverence or respect.

Chapter 6

[1] Children, obey your parents in the Lord,[a] for this is right. [2] "Honor
your father and your mother" (this is the first commandment with a
promise), [3] "so that it may go well with you and you may live long

on the earth.”[b] 4 Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but
bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.
5 Slaves,[c] obey those who are your masters in this life,[d] with fear
and trembling, with an undivided heart, as though you were obeying
Christ; 6 not only while you are watched, as people-pleasers,[e] but as
slaves of Christ, doing the will of God from the heart, 7 rendering
service with goodwill, as to the Lord and not to human beings, 8 for
you know that the Lord will repay each one for whatever good he
has done, whether slave or free. 9 And masters, do the same toward
them, and stop threatening them, knowing that both their Master and
yours is in heaven, and that with him there is no favoritism.[f]
10 Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the might of his strength. 11
Clothe yourselves in God’s full armor,[g] so that you may hold your
ground against the devil’s tactics. 12 We are not wrestling[h] with flesh
and blood; we are fighting the rulers, the authorities, the world
powers of this present darkness, the spiritual hosts of wickedness in
the heavenly realms. 13 That is why you must take up God’s full armor,
so that when the evil day comes you can withstand it, and after you
have done all you can, remain standing. 14 Stand, then, with the belt
of truth fastened around your waist,[i] and with righteousness as your
breastplate, 15 and with your feet fitted with readiness[j] for the good
news of peace. 16 Above all, lift the shield of faith,[k] by which you can
extinguish all the burning arrows shot by the evil one. 17 And take the
helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of
God. 18 Pray at every time in the Spirit, with every prayer and request.
To that end stay alert, with all perseverance and petition for all the
holy ones, 19 and also for me, that when I open my mouth, words may
be given to me so that I may boldly make known the secret of the
good news,[l] 20 for which I am an ambassador in chains, so that I may
declare it boldly, as I ought to speak.
21 Tychicus,[m] our dear brother and a faithful servant in the Lord, will
give you all the news, so that you too may know about my affairs and
how I am getting on. 22 That is exactly why I am sending him to you:
to let you know how things stand with us, and to encourage you.

[23] Peace be to the brothers,[n] and love with faith, from God the Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ. [24] Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus
Christ with a love that does not die.[o]

Notes

- a (6:1) In the Lord: the Westcott–Hort text brackets these words, which are absent from Vaticanus and some Western witnesses.
- b (6:3) Exod 20:12; Deut 5:16, in the wording of the Greek Old Testament of Deuteronomy. The commandment continues "in the land that Yahweh your God is giving you"; the letter omits these words. *On the earth* can also be translated "in the land."
- c (6:5) Slaves: Greek *douloi*, slaves or bond-servants, as in verses 6 and 8. Slavery was widespread in the Roman world, and many members of the early churches were slaves.
- d (6:5) Masters: Greek *kyrioi*, "lords," the same word as "Lord." Here "in this life" is literally "according to the flesh."
- e (6:6) Only while you are watched: literally "according to eye-service."
- f (6:9) Favoritism: Greek *prosōpolēmpsia*, literally "receiving of faces," a Hebrew idiom for partiality.
- g (6:11) Full armor: Greek *panoplia*, the complete equipment of a heavily armed soldier. The imagery of verses 14–17 draws on Isa 11:5; 52:7; 59:17.
- h (6:12) Wrestling: Greek *palē*, a wrestling match, a struggle.
- i (6:14) Waist: literally "loins."
- j (6:15) Readiness: or "firm footing"; Greek *hetoimasia* can mean either.
- k (6:16) Shield: Greek *thyreos*, the large, door-shaped shield of a Roman soldier, which could be soaked in water to put out burning arrows.
- l (6:19) Of the good news: the Westcott–Hort text brackets these words, which are absent from Vaticanus and some other witnesses.
- m (6:21) *Tychicus*: from Greek *tychē*, "fortune," "fortunate." He was from the province of Asia (Acts 20:4; Col 4:7; 2 Tim 4:12).
- n (6:23) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women.
- o (6:24) With a love that does not die: literally "in incorruption," "in immortality." The phrase may also go with "grace" or with "our Lord Jesus Christ." Later manuscripts add "Amen."

Philippians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul[a] and Timothy,[b] slaves[c] of Christ Jesus,[d] to all God's holy
people[e] in Christ Jesus who live in Philippi,[f] together with the over-
seers and helpers:[g] 2 grace and peace to you from God our Father and
from the Lord Jesus Christ.
3 Each time I call you to mind, I thank my God. 4 In every prayer I offer
for you all, my prayer is a joyful one, 5 because of your partnership
in spreading the good news[h] from the very first day until now. 6 I am
confident of this very thing, that the one who began a good work in
you will carry it through to its finish, right up to the day of Christ
Jesus. 7 And it is fitting that I should think this of you all, because
you are in my heart.[i] All of you are partners with me in grace,[j] in my
chains as well as in my defense and confirmation of the good news. 8
God is my witness how I long for all of you with the deep affection[k]
of Christ Jesus. 9 And I pray this: that your love may grow richer and
richer still in knowledge and in every kind of insight, 10 so that you
can approve the things that really matter,[l] and be pure and free from
fault on the day of Christ, 11 filled with the fruit of righteousness that
comes through Jesus Christ, to the glory and praise of God.
12 Brothers,[m] I want you to understand that what has happened to me
has actually served to move the good news forward. 13 The result is
that the whole imperial guard[n] and all the rest have come to see that
it is for Christ that I wear these chains. 14 And most of the brothers,
gaining confidence in the Lord from my imprisonment, are daring
all the more to speak the word of God without fear.[o] 15 Some indeed
preach Christ because they are envious and quarrelsome; but some
do it from good will. 16 These do it from love, knowing that I am
placed here to defend the good news. 17 The others announce Christ
from selfish ambition, not with pure motives, supposing that they

will make my chains harder to bear.[p] 18 What does it matter? Only that
in every way, whether for show or in truth, Christ is proclaimed; and
in that I rejoice. Yes, and I will go on rejoicing, 19 I know that this will
turn out for my deliverance,[q] through your prayers and the support
of the Spirit of Jesus Christ, 20 This is my eager expectation and hope:
that I will never be put to shame, but that, boldly now as always,
Christ will be magnified through my body, whether by my life or by
my death. 21 For me, to live is Christ, and to die is gain. 22 If I am to go
on living in the body, that means fruitful work for me, and I do not
know which I prefer.[r] 23 I am caught between two desires: I long to
depart and be with Christ, which would be far better, 24 but for your
sake it is more necessary that I remain in the body.[s] 25 Convinced of
this, I know that I will stay, and stay on with you all, for your progress
and joy in the faith, 26 so that when I come to you once more, your
pride in Christ Jesus may abound on my account.
27 Only, live as citizens[t] worthy of Christ's good news, so that whether
I come and see you or am away and hear about you, I may learn that
you are standing firm in a single spirit, contending together as one
soul for the faith that the good news brings, 28 not frightened in any
way by your opponents. To them this is a sign of their destruction,
but of your salvation, and this comes from God. 29 For it has been
granted to you, for Christ's sake, not only to believe in him but also
to suffer for him, 30 for you have the same contest on your hands as
you once saw me fight, and as you now hear I am fighting still.[u]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, "one who honors God," Paul's coworker, who had helped found the church at Philippi (Acts 16:1–12).
- c (1:1) Slaves: Greek *douloi*, slaves or bond-servants, wholly owned by their master.
- d (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah."
- e (1:1) God's holy people: Greek *hagioi*, "holy ones," traditionally "saints"; the believers as set apart for God.

- f (1:1) Philippi: a Roman colony in Macedonia (northern Greece), named after Philip II, father of Alexander the Great. Paul founded the church there about AD 49–50 (Acts 16:11–40); it was his first in Europe.
- g (1:1) Overseers and helpers: Greek *episkopoi* and *diakonoi*, traditionally "bishops and deacons," here probably local leaders and those who served the congregation.
- h (1:5) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally "gospel"; so throughout.
- i (1:7) Because you are in my heart: or "because you hold me in your heart"; the Greek can be read either way.
- j (1:7) Partners with me in grace: or "sharers in my grace," perhaps meaning the privilege of suffering for Christ (1:29).
- k (1:8) Deep affection: Greek *splanchna*, literally "inward parts," the seat of the emotions; also in 2:1.
- l (1:10) Approve the things that really matter: or "test the things that differ."
- m (1:12) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women; so throughout.
- n (1:13) Imperial guard: Greek *praitōrion*, either the Praetorian Guard, the emperor's bodyguard in Rome, or the governor's headquarters in a provincial capital (as in Acts 23:35).
- o (1:14) Of God: some manuscripts lack these words; others read "of the Lord."
- p (1:17) Later manuscripts reverse the order of verses 16 and 17.
- q (1:19) This will turn out for my deliverance: the exact wording of Job 13:16 in the Greek Old Testament. *Deliverance* (Greek *sōtēria*) can also mean "salvation," or vindication before God.
- r (1:22) The Greek of this verse is broken and can be punctuated in several ways.
- s (1:24) In the body: literally "in the flesh," as also in verse 22.
- t (1:27) Live as citizens: Greek *politeuesthe*, a striking word in a letter to a Roman colony whose people prized their citizenship (compare 3:20).
- u (1:30) Compare Acts 16:19–24; 1 Thess 2:2.

Chapter 2

1 If, then, Christ gives you any encouragement, if love brings you any
consolation, if you have any fellowship in the Spirit,[a] if you know
any tenderness and pity, 2 then complete my joy by thinking alike,
having the same love, being one in soul and one in mind. 3 Do nothing
out of rivalry or empty conceit; instead, in humility count others as
better than yourselves. 4 Each of you should keep an eye not just on
what concerns yourself, but on what concerns others as well. 5 Let
this mind be in you that was also in Christ Jesus:[b]

6 Though he was in the form of God,[c]
  he did not regard being equal with God
  as something to be grasped,[d]
7 but he emptied himself,[e]
  taking the form of a slave,
  being made in human likeness.
  And when he was found in human shape,
8 he humbled himself
  and became obedient as far as death,
  even death on a cross.
9 For this reason God raised him to the very highest
  and graciously gave him that name
  which is above all names,
10 so that at Jesus' name
  every knee may bow,
  of those in heaven, on earth, and beneath the earth,
11 and every tongue confess
  that Jesus Christ is Lord,
  to the glory of God the Father.[f]
12 So, my dear friends, just as you have always obeyed, not only when I was present but much more now that I am absent, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, 13 God is the one working in you, both the willing and the doing, for the sake of what pleases him. 14 Do everything without grumbling or arguing, 15 so that you may be faultless and pure, God's children without defect among a warped and crooked generation,[g] in which you shine like stars in the universe,[h] 16 holding fast[i] the word of life, so that I may have reason to boast on the day of Christ that I did not run in vain or toil in vain.[j] 17 Even if my life is being poured out like a drink offering[k] on the sacrifice and service that come from your faith, I am glad and I celebrate with every one of you. 18 You also should be glad, and celebrate with me.

19 I hope in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you soon, so that I also may be cheered by news of you. 20 I have no one else like him, who will care with genuine concern for your welfare. 21 Everyone else is

seeking what is his own, not what is Jesus Christ's. 22 You know how
he has proved himself: like a child alongside his father, he has slaved
with me for the good news. 23 So he is the one I hope to send, the
moment I can see what will happen to me. 24 and I trust in the Lord
that I myself will also come soon.
25 I have thought it necessary, though, to send back to you Epaphrodi-
tus,[l] my brother, fellow worker, and fellow soldier, whom you sent as
your messenger[m] to minister to my needs. 26 He has been homesick for
you all, and upset that word of his sickness reached you. 27 He really
was sick, almost dying. But God showed mercy to him, and not only
to him but to me, so that I would be spared one sorrow after another.
28 I am the more eager to send him, therefore, so that when you see
him again you may rejoice, and I may be less anxious. 29 So welcome
him in the Lord with all joy, and hold people like him in honor, 30 for
he nearly died for Christ's work,[n] gambling with his life to complete
the service you yourselves could not give me.

Notes

- a (2:1) Fellowship in the Spirit: or "fellowship with the Spirit," "a share in the Spirit."
- b (2:5) Let this mind be in you ...: or "Think among yourselves in the way that is fitting for those who are in Christ Jesus." The Greek is compressed and can be read either way. Verses 6–11 are widely thought to be an early Christian hymn, either composed by Paul or quoted by him.
- c (2:6) Form: Greek *morphē*, the outward shape that expresses what something truly is; also in verse 7.
- d (2:6) Something to be grasped: Greek *harpagmos*, a rare word meaning either something seized or something to be clung to or exploited for one's own advantage. Scholars are divided.
- e (2:7) Emptied himself: Greek *ekenōsen*, "made himself empty" or "poured himself out"; the following phrases explain how.
- f (2:11) Verses 10–11: Isa 45:23, where in the Hebrew it is Yahweh who says, "To me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear." Here the homage due to Yahweh is given to Jesus, and the name above every name (verse 9) is probably *Lord* (*kyrios*), the Greek Old Testament's rendering of the divine name. *Under the earth*: the realm of the dead.
- g (2:15) A crooked and twisted generation: from Deut 32:5 in the Greek Old Testament, where the phrase describes Israel in the wilderness, whose grumbling (verse 14) is a theme of the Exodus story.

- h (2:15) Stars: Greek *phōstēres*, “lights,” “luminaries,” the word used of the sun, moon and stars in Gen 1:14–16 and of the wise in Dan 12:3 in the Greek Old Testament.
- i (2:16) Holding fast: or “holding out”; Greek *epechō* can mean either.
- j (2:16) Compare Isa 49:4; 65:23.
- k (2:17) Poured out as a drink offering: Greek *spendomai*, used of wine poured out over or beside a sacrifice (Num 28:7); Paul speaks of his possible death.
- l (2:25) *Epaphroditus*: Greek, “charming” or “belonging to Aphrodite,” a common name. He is probably not the same person as Epaphras of Colossae (Col 1:7).
- m (2:25) Messenger: Greek *apostolos*, “one sent,” here an envoy of the church, not an apostle in the narrower sense.
- n (2:30) Christ’s work: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Vaticanus; other manuscripts read “of the Lord,” and some have neither.

Chapter 3

1 Finally, my brothers, rejoice in the Lord. To write the same things
to you is no trouble for me, and for you it is a safeguard.
2 Beware the dogs! Beware the workers of evil! Beware the cutters![a]
3 We are the true circumcision, we who serve by God’s Spirit,[b] take
pride in Christ Jesus, and place no trust in human credentials, 4 I
could put confidence in the flesh myself, if I chose. Does someone
else imagine he has reason to rely on the flesh? I have more: 5 I
was circumcised when eight days old; I am an Israelite by race, a
Benjaminite by tribe,[c] a Hebrew of Hebrew parents; regarding the
law I was a Pharisee; 6 regarding zeal, I persecuted the church;
regarding the righteousness that the law requires, I was faultless. 7 Yet
all that was profit to me, I have reckoned as loss for Christ’s sake. 8
Indeed, I reckon everything a loss, compared with the supreme value
of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord. For him I have lost everything,
and I think of it all as garbage,[d] if only I may gain Christ 9 and be
found in him, without any righteousness of my own based on the
law, but having the righteousness that is through faith in Christ,[e] a
righteousness from God, resting on faith. 10 I want to know him and
the power of his resurrection and the sharing of his sufferings, being
shaped to share his death, 11 in hope that I may somehow arrive at the
resurrection from among the dead.

12 I am not claiming that I have already obtained this or have already
been made perfect; but I press on, hoping to grasp the purpose for
which Christ Jesus grasped me. 13 Brothers, I do not reckon that I have
yet laid hold of it. Only this: I forget what is behind, I stretch out
toward what is in front, 14 I press on toward the goal for the prize of
the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.[f] 15 All of us who are mature
should take this view; and if on any point you see things differently,
God will make that clear to you as well. 16 Only let us keep in line with
what we have already attained.[g]
17 Brothers, join together in imitating me, and keep your eyes on those
who live by the example you have in us. 18 For many, as I have often
told you before and now tell you weeping, walk as enemies of Christ's
cross. 19 Destruction is where they will end. Their stomach is their
god; they glory in what should shame them; earthly things fill their
thoughts. 20 But our citizenship[h] is in heaven, and from there we are
eagerly awaiting a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ. 21 By the power with
which he can make all things subject to himself, he will change the
body of our humiliation and conform it to the body of his glory.

Notes

- a (3:2) Dogs ... cutters: harsh terms for those who insisted that Gentile believers be circumcised. *Dogs* was an insult some Jews used of Gentiles, here turned back on them; *cutters* (Greek *katatomē*, "mutilation," "cutting up") is a bitter play on *peritomē*, "circumcision" (verse 3).
- b (3:3) By the Spirit of God: some manuscripts, including P46 as reported, read "worship God in the Spirit."
- c (3:5) *Benjamin*: Hebrew, "son of the right hand" (Gen 35:18), the tribe of King Saul, after whom Paul was named. *Pharisee*: probably "separated one," a member of the lay movement devoted to strict observance of the Law and its traditions.
- d (3:8) Garbage: Greek *skybala*, refuse or dung.
- e (3:9) Faith in Christ: or "the faithfulness of Christ."
- f (3:14) Prize: Greek *brabeion*, the award given to the winner in the athletic games. *Upward call*: or "heavenly call."
- g (3:16) Later manuscripts add "Let us be of the same mind" and similar words.
- h (3:20) Citizenship: Greek *politeuma*, the commonwealth or state to which one belongs; compare 1:27.

Chapter 4

1 So then, my brothers, beloved and longed for, you who are my joy
and my crown,[a] stand firm like this in the Lord, dear friends.
2 I appeal to Euodia and I appeal to Syntyche[b] to agree with each other
in the Lord. 3 Yes, and I ask you too, my true companion,[c] help these
women, for they have contended side by side with me in the work
of the good news, together with Clement[d] and the rest of my fellow
workers, whose names are in the book of life.
4 Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say it: rejoice. 5 Make your
gentleness known to all people. The Lord is close at hand.[e] 6 Stop
worrying about anything; in every situation, through prayer and
requests with thanksgiving, bring your needs to God. 7 And the peace
of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts
and your minds in Christ Jesus.
8 Finally, brothers, whatever things are true, worthy of respect, right,
pure, lovable, well spoken of — if there is any virtue, any praise —
let your thoughts dwell on these. 9 Put into practice the things you
learned from me and received, the things you heard from me and saw
in me; and the God of peace will be with you.
10 It gave me great joy in the Lord that your care for me has blossomed
again at last. You were caring all along, of course, but you lacked
the chance. 11 I do not say this out of want; I have learned to be self-
sufficient,[f] whatever my situation. 12 I know what it is to be brought
low, and I know what it is to have more than enough. In each and
every case I have been initiated into the secret of being full and of
being hungry, of abundance and of want. 13 I can do all things through
him who gives me strength.[g] 14 Yet you did well to share in my distress.
15 And you Philippians know yourselves that in the early days of
the good news, when I set out from Macedonia, no church shared
with me in the matter of giving and receiving except you alone. 16
for even when I was in Thessalonica[h] you sent me something for my
need, once and then again. 17 Not that I seek the gift, but I seek the
profit that increases to your credit.[i] 18 I now have everything, and
more than enough. I am amply provided for, having received from
Epaphroditus what you sent: a fragrant aroma,[j] a sacrifice that God

accepts and finds pleasing. [19] And my God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus. [20] To our God and Father be the glory for ever and ever. Amen.

[21] Greet every holy one in Christ Jesus. The brothers who are with me greet you. [22] All the holy ones greet you, especially those of Caesar's household.[k]

[23] The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.[l]

Notes

- a (4:1) Crown: Greek *stephanos*, the wreath given to a victor in the games or to an honored guest at a feast.
- b (4:2) *Euodia*: Greek, "a good journey" or "fragrance." *Syntyche*: Greek, "good fortune" or "companion." Both were women who had worked with Paul (verse 3).
- c (4:3) True companion: Greek *gnēsie syzyge*, "genuine yokefellow." Some take *Syzygus* as a personal name, which would then mean "true to your name."
- d (4:3) *Clement*: Latin *Clemens*, "merciful," "gentle."
- e (4:5) The Lord is close at hand: or "the Lord is near," perhaps an echo of Ps 145:18 (144:18 in the Greek Old Testament), where "the Lord" is Yahweh in the Hebrew. The words may refer to the Lord's nearness in place or to his coming in time.
- f (4:11) Self-sufficient: Greek *autarkēs*, "content," "self-sufficient," a key term of Stoic philosophy; Paul's sufficiency comes from the one who strengthens him (verse 13).
- g (4:13) Him: later manuscripts read "Christ."
- h (4:16) Thessalonica: the capital of the province of Macedonia, about 90 miles (150 km) west of Philippi (Acts 17:1–9).
- i (4:17) Profit … to your credit: the language of bookkeeping, used throughout verses 15–18.
- j (4:18) A fragrant aroma: literally "an odor of fragrance," the Greek Old Testament phrase for a sacrifice acceptable to God (Gen 8:21; Exod 29:18).
- k (4:22) Caesar's household: the slaves and freedmen in the service of the emperor, who worked in Rome and throughout the empire.
- l (4:23) Later manuscripts add "Amen."

Colossians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From Paul,[a] an apostle[b] of Christ Jesus[c] through God's will, and from
Timothy[d] our brother, 2 to the holy and faithful brothers[e] in Christ at
Colossae: grace to you and peace from God our Father.[f]
3 Whenever we pray for you, we give thanks to God, the Father of our
Lord Jesus Christ, 4 since word has reached us of your faith in Christ
Jesus and of the love you hold for all God's holy people.[g] 5 This springs
from the hope stored up for you in heaven. You heard of it before, in
the message of truth, the good news[h] 6 that has come to you. All over
the world that good news is bearing fruit and spreading, just as it has
done among you since the day you heard it and came to know God's
grace as it truly is. 7 You learned it from Epaphras,[i] our dear fellow
slave, who serves Christ faithfully on our behalf.[j] 8 It was he who told
us of your love in the Spirit.
9 For this reason, from the day we heard, we have not ceased praying
for you. We ask that you may be filled with the knowledge of what
God wills, with all the wisdom and understanding the Spirit gives, 10 so
that you may walk worthily of the Lord, pleasing him in all respects,
fruitful in good work of every kind, and growing in your knowledge
of God; 11 made strong with all strength, as his glorious might supplies,
so that you may endure everything and be patient, with joy; 12 and
thanking the Father, who has made you fit[k] to share the lot of the holy
ones in the light.[l] 13 He rescued us from the dominion of darkness and
moved us into the kingdom of the Son he loves.[m] 14 It is in him that
we are redeemed and our sins are forgiven.[n]
15 He is the image of the invisible God, firstborn before all creation,[o] 16
since in him all things were created, in the heavens and on the earth,
what can be seen and what cannot, whether thrones or lordships or
rulers or authorities.[p] Everything has been created through him and

for him. 17 He exists before everything, and in him everything holds
together. 18 He is also the head of the body, the church. He is the
beginning, firstborn from among the dead, so that in all things he
himself might come to hold first place. 19 For in him all the fullness
was pleased to dwell,[q] 20 and through him to bring everything back
into harmony with himself, establishing peace by the blood shed on
his cross[r] — everything on earth and everything in heaven.
21 You were once estranged from God and his enemies in your think-
ing, as shown by the wicked things you did; 22 he has now reconciled[s]
in his body of flesh through his death, so as to bring you into his
presence holy, spotless and free from any charge, 23 provided you
continue in the faith, grounded and steady and not shifted from the
hope held out in the good news you heard. That good news has been
proclaimed to every creature under heaven, and I, Paul, became its
servant.[t]
24 I am glad now to suffer for you. In my own flesh I am completing
what remains of Christ's afflictions,[u] for the sake of his body, the
church. 25 I became the church's servant by the commission[v] God gave
me for your benefit: to bring God's word to its full completion, 26 the
secret[w] that was kept hidden through ages and generations but has
now been revealed to his holy ones. 27 To them God chose to make
known how rich and glorious this secret is among the Gentiles:[x] it is
Christ in you, the hope of glory. 28 He is the one we announce. We
warn and instruct everyone, with all the wisdom we have, so that we
may present[y] each one mature in Christ. 29 To this end I toil and strive,
with all the energy he so powerfully works in me.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, "one who is sent," a messenger with the authority of the sender.
- c (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah."
- d (1:1) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, "one who honors God."

- e (1:2) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women; so throughout.
- f (1:2) God our Father: later manuscripts add “and the Lord Jesus Christ.”
- g (1:4) God’s holy people: Greek *hagioi*, “holy ones,” traditionally “saints”; so throughout.
- h (1:5) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally “gospel”; so throughout.
- i (1:7) *Epaphras*: a short form of *Epaphroditus*, “charming.” He was a native of Colossae (4:12) who evidently founded the church there; he was later in prison with Paul (Phlm 23).
- j (1:7) On our behalf: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus as reported; many manuscripts read “on your behalf.”
- k (1:12) You: some manuscripts read “us.”
- l (1:12) The lot: Greek *klēros*, a portion assigned by lot, as Canaan was shared out among the tribes of Israel (Josh 14:1–2).
- m (1:13) The Son he loves: literally “the Son of his love.”
- n (1:14) Later manuscripts add “through his blood,” from Eph 1:7.
- o (1:15) Firstborn: Greek *prōtotokos*, a title of rank and preeminence as well as of priority in time (compare Ps 89:27). Verses 15–20 are widely thought to be an early Christian hymn.
- p (1:16) Thrones … authorities: ranks of spiritual powers, as in Eph 1:21.
- q (1:19) All the fullness was pleased: or “God was pleased that all the fullness should dwell”; compare 2:9.
- r (1:20) Of his cross: the Westcott–Hort text adds “through him” in brackets.
- s (1:22) He has now reconciled: Vaticanus and P46 as reported read “you have now been reconciled.”
- t (1:23) Servant: Greek *diakonos*, “servant” or “minister”; also in verse 25.
- u (1:24) What remains of Christ’s afflictions: literally “what is lacking of the afflictions of Christ”; not a deficiency in Christ’s saving death, but probably the sufferings that Christ’s people must bear, in which Christ shares (compare Acts 9:4), or the trials expected before the end.
- v (1:25) Commission: Greek *oikonomia*, “stewardship,” the task given to a household manager.
- w (1:26) Secret: Greek *mystērion*, traditionally “mystery,” not a puzzle but God’s purpose once hidden and now disclosed; so throughout.
- x (1:27) Gentiles: Greek *ethnē*, “nations,” the non-Jewish peoples.
- y (1:28) Present: that is, present before God.

Chapter 2

1 I want you to know how hard I struggle for you, for those at Laodicea,[a] and for everyone who has not seen me face to face.[b] 2 My goal is that their hearts will be comforted and held together in love,

and that they will gain the full wealth of confident understanding and recognize God's mystery, which is Christ.[c] 3 In him lie hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. 4 I say this so that no one may mislead you with persuasive talk. 5 For though I am absent in body, I am with you in spirit, and I am delighted to see how orderly you are and how firm your faith in Christ is.[d]

6 Therefore, as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so go on living in him,[e] 7 rooted in him and built up in him, made firm in the faith as you were taught, and brimming over with thanksgiving. 8 See to it that no one carries you off as plunder by means of philosophy, by hollow deception that follows the traditions of men and the elemental forces of the world,[f] and does not follow Christ. 9 For in him the whole fullness of deity lives in bodily form, 10 and it is in him, the head of every ruler and power, that you have been made full. 11 In him you were also circumcised, with a circumcision not done by hands, by stripping off the body of the flesh,[g] in the circumcision of Christ. 12 You were buried with him in baptism, and with him you were also raised through faith in the working of God, who raised him from the dead. 13 And when you were dead in your wrongdoings and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made you alive together with him. He forgave us all our wrongdoings,[h] 14 He wiped out the bond that was written against us, with its decrees that opposed us.[i] He has taken it out of the way, fastening it with nails to the cross. 15 He stripped the rulers and authorities,[j] put them on open display, and led them along in his triumphal procession by means of the cross.

16 So do not let anyone pass judgment on you over food or drink, or in the matter of a festival or new moon or sabbath. 17 They are only a shadow of things that were coming; the body that casts it is Christ's.[k] 18 Let no one disqualify you,[l] insisting on self-abasement and the worship of angels,[m] going on about what he has seen,[n] puffed up without reason by his fleshly mind, 19 and not holding fast to the head. From him the whole body, supported and held together by its joints and ligaments, grows with a growth that comes from God. 20 If with Christ you died to the elemental forces of the world, why do you submit to regulations as though you still lived in the world: 21 "Hands off! Taste

nothing! Touch nothing!” 22 All these things perish as they are used.
They are based on human commands and teachings.[o] 23 These rules do
appear wise, with their invented religion, their humility, their harsh
handling of the body; but they are worth nothing at all in checking
the indulgence of the flesh.[p]

Notes

- a (2:1) Laodicea: a prosperous city about 10 miles (16 km) west of Colossae (compare Rev 3:14–22).
- b (2:1) Face to face: literally “my face in the flesh.”
- c (2:2) God’s secret, which is Christ: so the Westcott–Hort text (literally “the secret of God, Christ”), reported for P46 and Vaticanus. Few passages have so many variant readings; others include “of God,” “of Christ,” “of God, which is Christ,” “of God the Father of Christ,” and “of God and of the Father and of Christ.” The many forms probably arose as scribes tried to clarify the short reading.
- d (2:5) Orderly … firm: military terms, *taxis* (“ranks,” “order”) and *stereōma* (“solid front”).
- e (2:6) Living: literally “walking,” a Hebrew idiom for one’s conduct; so throughout.
- f (2:8) Elemental forces: Greek *stoicheia*, the basic elements or principles; also in verse 20 (see the note on Gal 4:3).
- g (2:11) Later manuscripts add “of sins.”
- h (2:13) Us: some manuscripts read “you.”
- i (2:14) Bond: Greek *cheirographon*, a handwritten certificate of debt signed by the debtor.
- j (2:15) Stripped: or “disarmed.” *Triumphal procession*: as a victorious Roman general paraded his captives through the city. *By means of the cross*: literally “in it”; or “in him.”
- k (2:17) The body that casts it: literally “the body,” the reality in contrast to the shadow.
- l (2:18) Disqualify: Greek *katabrabeuō*, to rule against someone, as an umpire might deny an athlete the prize.
- m (2:18) Worship of angels: either worship offered to angels, or the worship angels offer, which some claimed to share in visions.
- n (2:18) Going on about what he has seen: the Greek is obscure. *Embateuō* may mean “enter into,” perhaps a term from initiation rites. Later manuscripts read “what he has not seen.”
- o (2:22) Compare Isa 29:13.
- p (2:23) The Greek of this verse is difficult, and its last clause can also be understood as “they serve only to indulge the flesh.”

Chapter 3

1 Since, then, you were raised together with Christ, aim for what is
above, where Christ sits at God's right hand.[a] 2 Set your minds on
things above, not on earthly things. 3 For you have died, and your life
is hidden with Christ in God. 4 When Christ appears, he who is our
life,[b] you too will appear with him, in glory.
5 So put to death whatever in you belongs to the earth:[c] sexual
immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and greed, which is idola-
try. 6 Because of these things the wrath of God is coming.[d] 7 You too
once followed these ways, when you lived among them. 8 But now
you must put all of them away: anger, rage, malice, slander, and foul
language from your mouths. 9 Stop lying to each other. You have taken
off the old self[e] and its ways of acting, 10 and clothed yourselves with
the new, which is constantly made new, so as to know God fully, after
the likeness of the one who created it.[f] 11 In this new life it makes no
difference whether one is Greek or Jew, circumcised or not, barbarian
or Scythian,[g] slave or free. Christ is everything, and he is in everyone.
12 So then, since God has chosen you, made you holy, and loved
you, put on heartfelt compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and
patience as your clothing. 13 Put up with each other; and if one of you
has reason to blame another, be gracious and forgive. The Lord[h] has
forgiven you; you must do likewise. 14 Over all these clothe yourselves
with love, the bond that holds all perfection together.[i] 15 Let the peace
of Christ rule[j] in your hearts, since you were called to it as members
of one body. And be thankful. 16 Let Christ's message live among you
in all its fullness. Teach and counsel each other with all wisdom, and
with thankful hearts sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs to God.
17 And whatever you do, in word or deed, do it all in the name of the
Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.
18 Wives, be subject to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord. 19
Husbands, love your wives, and never treat them bitterly. 20 Children,
obey your parents in all things, for in the Lord this is pleasing. 21
Fathers, do not exasperate your children, so that they do not become
discouraged. 22 Slaves,[k] obey your earthly masters[l] in everything, not
only when they are watching, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity

of heart, fearing the Lord. 23 Whatever you do, work at it wholeheartedly, as for the Lord and not for people, 24 since you know that you will receive the inheritance from the Lord as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ. 25 Whoever does wrong will get back the wrong he did, and no partiality will be shown.[m]

Notes

- a (3:1) Sits at God's right hand: an echo of Ps 110:1 (109:1 in the Greek Old Testament).
- b (3:4) Our: some manuscripts read "your."
- c (3:5) Whatever in you belongs to the earth: literally "the members that are on the earth."
- d (3:6) Many manuscripts add "on the children of disobedience," from Eph 5:6; the Westcott–Hort text, with P46 and Vaticanus as reported, lacks it.
- e (3:9) Self: literally "man" (Greek *anthrōpos*, "human being").
- f (3:10) Compare Gen 1:26–27.
- g (3:11) Barbarian: one who did not speak Greek. *Scythian*: a people north of the Black Sea, regarded by Greeks as the most uncivilized of barbarians.
- h (3:13) The Lord: some manuscripts read "Christ," others "God."
- i (3:14) The bond that holds all perfection together: literally "the bond of perfection," or "of completeness."
- j (3:15) Rule: Greek *brabeuō*, to act as umpire.
- k (3:22) Slaves: Greek *douloi*, slaves or bond-servants. Slavery was widespread in the Roman world, and many members of the early churches were slaves; compare Philemon.
- l (3:22) Masters: Greek *kyrioi*, "lords," the same word as "Lord" throughout verses 22–24; *earthly* is literally "according to the flesh."
- m (3:25) Partiality: literally "receiving of faces," a Hebrew idiom for partiality.

Chapter 4

1 Masters, give your slaves what is right and fair; remember that you also have a Master in heaven.

2 Keep at prayer, staying alert in it with thanksgiving. 3 And pray for us at the same time, asking God to open up a door for the word, that we may speak of Christ's secret, the reason I am bound, 4 and that I may make it clear, as I ought to speak. 5 Walk in wisdom toward outsiders, making the most of the time.[a] 6 Your words should always be full of grace and flavored with salt, so that you will know what answer to give to each one.

7 Tychicus[b] will tell you all about my affairs. He is a dear brother, a
faithful servant and a fellow slave in the Lord. 8 That is the very reason
I have sent him to you: to let you know our situation,[c] and to bring
comfort to your hearts. 9 He comes with Onesimus,[d] our faithful and
dear brother, who is one of you. They will tell you about everything
here.
10 Greetings from Aristarchus,[e] who is in prison with me, and from
Mark, Barnabas's cousin.[f] You have had orders concerning Mark:
make him welcome if he comes to you. 11 Greetings, too, from Jesus
called Justus.[g] Of the circumcised, these three alone are working with
me for God's kingdom, and they have proved a great comfort to me. 12
Epaphras, who is one of you, a slave of Christ Jesus, sends greetings.
He is always wrestling in his prayers on your behalf, that you may
stand mature and fully assured in all the will of God. 13 For I testify
that he has worked hard for you and for those in Laodicea and in
Hierapolis.[h] 14 Luke,[i] the beloved physician, greets you, and so does
Demas.[j] 15 Greet the brothers at Laodicea, and also Nympha, with the
church that meets in her house.[k] 16 And when this letter has been read
among you, see that it is also read in the church of the Laodiceans, and
that you in turn read the letter from Laodicea.[l] 17 And tell Archippus,[m]
"See that you complete the ministry you have received in the Lord."
18 I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand.[n] Remember my
chains. Grace be with you.[o]

Notes

- a (4:5) Making the most of the time: literally "buying up the opportunity."
- b (4:7) *Tychicus*: from Greek *tychē*, "fortune," "fortunate." He was from the province of Asia (Acts 20:4; Eph 6:21–22).
- c (4:8) Our situation: literally "the things concerning us"; so the Westcott–Hort text; many manuscripts read "that he may know your situation."
- d (4:9) *Onesimus*: Greek, "useful," a common name for slaves. He is the runaway slave of the letter to Philemon (Phlm 10).
- e (4:10) *Aristarchus*: Greek, "best ruler." He was from Thessalonica and traveled with Paul (Acts 19:29; 20:4; 27:2).
- f (4:10) *Mark*: Latin *Marcus*, a common Roman name; the John Mark of Acts 12:12, 25; 15:37–39. *Barnabas*: interpreted in Acts 4:36 as "son of encouragement."
- g (4:11) *Jesus*: a common Jewish name, the Greek form of Joshua. *Justus*: Latin, "just," "righteous," a name often taken by Jews.

- h (4:13) Hierapolis: a city about 6 miles (10 km) north of Laodicea, famous for its hot springs.
- i (4:14) *Luke*: Latin *Lucas*, perhaps short for *Lucanus* or *Lucius*. By tradition he is the author of the Gospel of Luke and Acts.
- j (4:14) *Demas*: probably a short form of *Demetrius*, "belonging to Demeter." He later deserted Paul (2 Tim 4:10).
- k (4:15) *Nympha*: Greek, "bride," a woman's name. Some manuscripts read the man's name *Nymphas* and "his house"; others read "their house."
- l (4:16) The letter from Laodicea: a letter otherwise unknown, unless it is the letter now called Ephesians (see the note on Eph 1:1) or Philemon. A later forged "Letter to the Laodiceans" survives in Latin.
- m (4:17) *Archippus*: Greek, "master of horses." He is also greeted in Phlm 2.
- n (4:18) Paul usually dictated his letters to a scribe and added a closing in his own handwriting (2 Thess 3:17).
- o (4:18) Later manuscripts add "Amen."

1 Thessalonians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] Silvanus[b] and Timothy,[c] to the church of the Thessalonians[d] in
God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ:[e] grace to you, and peace.[f]
2 At all times we thank God for every one of you, and mention
you in our prayers. 3 Without ceasing we call to mind, before our
God and Father, how your faith is at work, how your love labors,
and how your hope in our Lord Jesus Christ holds steady.[g] 4 For we
know, brothers[h] whom God loves, that he has chosen you, 5 for our
gospel message[i] reached you not merely as words but with power,
with the Holy Spirit, and with full assurance. You remember how
we conducted ourselves among you, for your benefit. 6 And you
became imitators of us and of the Lord; in spite of great affliction you
welcomed the message with the joy the Holy Spirit gives. 7 As a result
you became an example to every believer in Macedonia and Achaia.[j]
8 The Lord's word has sounded forth from you like a trumpet, and
not in Macedonia and Achaia only; in every place the news of your
faith toward God has spread abroad, so we need say nothing about
it. 9 People themselves report what kind of welcome we had among
you, and how you turned to God from idols, to serve a God who is
living and true, 10 and to wait for his Son from heaven, Jesus, whom he
raised from the dead, who rescues us from the wrath that is coming.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) *Silvanus*: Latin, "of the forest," the Roman form of the name *Silas* (Acts 15:40; 17:4), probably from Aramaic *She'ila*, "asked for."
- c (1:1) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, "one who honors God."
- d (1:1) Thessalonians: the people of Thessalonica, the capital of the Roman province of Macedonia, a major port on the Egnatian Way, the road that crossed northern Greece.

- e (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), “Yahweh saves.” *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, “Anointed One,” equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, “Messiah.”
- f (1:1) Later manuscripts add “from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.”
- g (1:3) Holds steady: literally “the endurance of hope.”
- h (1:4) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women; so throughout.
- i (1:5) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally “gospel”; so throughout.
- j (1:7) Macedonia … Achaia: the two Roman provinces of northern and southern Greece.

Chapter 2

1 You yourselves know, brothers, that our visit to you was not in vain.
2 As you know, we had already suffered and been shamefully treated
at Philippi,[a] yet with our God’s help we found the courage to tell
you God’s good news in the face of great opposition. 3 For our appeal
did not spring from error or impure motives, nor did it use trickery.
4 Rather, just as God has tested us and entrusted us with the good
news, so we speak, not to please human beings, but to please God,
who tests our hearts. 5 As you know, we never came with flattering
words, nor with a pretext for greed — God is our witness — 6 We
did not look for praise from people, whether from you or anyone
else, though as apostles[b] of Christ we might have insisted on our
importance.[c] 7 Instead we became like little children among you.[d] As
a nurse cherishes her own children, 8 In the same way, because we
cared so much for you, we were delighted to give you not just God’s
gospel but our own selves, since you had grown so precious to us. 9
You remember, brothers and sisters, our hard work and exhaustion:
we labored night and day so that we would not be a burden to any of
you while we announced God’s gospel to you. 10 You can testify, and
so can God, how holy, upright and beyond reproach our conduct was
among you who believe. 11 You know how, like a father with his own
children, we treated each one of you, encouraging and comforting
you 12 and pleading with you to walk[e] in a manner that befits the God
who is calling you to his own kingdom and glory.
13 This is another reason we give thanks to God unceasingly: when
the word of God reached you through our preaching, you took it in,

not as the word of mere humans, but as what it really is, God's word, now active in you who believe. 14 For you, brothers, have followed the pattern of the churches of God in Judea that are in Christ Jesus. You have suffered from your own fellow citizens just as they did from the Judeans,[f] 15 who killed both the Lord Jesus and the prophets, and drove us out. They displease God and oppose all people, 16 who try to stop us speaking to the Gentiles[g] for their salvation. In this way they are always filling up their sins to the brim. But the wrath has overtaken them at last.[h]

17 But we, brothers, when we were torn away from you for a short time,[i] in person but not in heart, longed all the more eagerly to see you face to face. 18 We wanted to visit you — I, Paul, again and again[j] — but Satan[k] stood in our way. 19 For who is our hope, our joy, the crown we will boast of in the presence of our Lord Jesus when he comes?[l] Who, if not you? 20 Yes, you are our glory and our joy.

Notes

- a (2:2) Philippi: see Acts 16:19–40.
- b (2:6) Apostles: Greek *apostoloi*, "those who are sent," messengers with the authority of the sender.
- c (2:6) Made our weight felt: or "been a burden to you" (compare 2:9); the Greek *en barei* can mean either weight of authority or financial burden. In some editions these words begin verse 7.
- d (2:7) Like little children: Greek *nēpioi*, "infants," the reading of the Westcott–Hort text and of the earliest manuscripts, including P65, the original hand of Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus as reported. Many manuscripts read *ēpioi*, "gentle," which differs by a single letter; the preceding word ends in *n*, so either could have arisen from the other by a slip of the eye. Many modern translations prefer "gentle" as better suited to the context.
- e (2:12) Walk: a Hebrew idiom for one's conduct; so throughout.
- f (2:14) The Judeans: Greek *Ioudaioi*, here probably the people of Judea who opposed the churches there, not the Jewish people as a whole; Paul himself and the Judean churches were Jewish.
- g (2:16) Gentiles: Greek *ethnē*, "nations," the non-Jewish peoples.
- h (2:16) At last: or "completely," "to the end." Because of the harshness of verses 14–16 and the apparent reference to a past disaster, some scholars think they were added after the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70; no manuscript lacks them, and most scholars regard them as Paul's.
- i (2:17) A short time: literally "a season of an hour," an idiom for a brief time.
- j (2:18) More than once: literally "both once and twice," an idiom.

- k (2:18) Satan: Hebrew, “adversary,” “accuser.”
- l (2:19) When he comes: literally “at his coming,” Greek *parousia*, “presence,” “arrival,” used of the visit of a ruler; so throughout. *Crown*: the victor’s wreath.

Chapter 3

1 So, since we could stand it no longer, we thought it best to stay
behind in Athens[a] by ourselves, 2 and we sent Timothy, our brother
and God’s servant[b] in the good news of Christ, to make you firm
and to encourage you for the sake of your faith, 3 so that none of
you would be unsettled by these troubles. You know well that we are
appointed for them. 4 In fact, when we were with you, we kept telling
you beforehand that we were going to suffer affliction, and so it has
turned out, as you know. 5 So I too, unable to stand it any longer,
sent to learn how your faith was holding up. I feared that the tempter
might somehow have tempted you, and that all our work would come
to nothing. 6 Timothy, however, has come back to us from you just
now, bringing good news of your faith and your love. He tells us that
your memories of us are always warm, and that you long to see us, as
we long to see you. 7 That is why, brothers, your faith has comforted
us concerning you, in the midst of all our hardship and trouble. 8 For
now we live, if you stand firm in the Lord. 9 What thanks can we
ever give back to God for you, for all the joy with which we rejoice
over you in our God’s presence? 10 Night and day we beg him, with
the utmost urgency, to let us see your faces and make good whatever
your faith still lacks.
11 Now may our God and Father himself, and our Lord Jesus, direct
our way to you. 12 And as for you, may the Lord cause your love to
grow and overflow, toward each other and toward everyone, just as
ours does toward you, 13 so that he may strengthen your hearts to be
blameless in holiness before our God and Father at the coming of our
Lord Jesus with all his holy ones.[c]

Notes

- a (3:1) Athens: see Acts 17:15–34.
- b (3:2) God’s servant: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus as reported. Some manuscripts, reportedly including Vaticanus, read “God’s coworker”; others read “our coworker,” and many combine the two.

- c (3:13) With all his holy ones: echoing Zech 14:5, “Yahweh my God will come, and all the holy ones with him.” The holy ones may be angels or God’s people, or both. Some manuscripts add “Amen.”

Chapter 4

1 Finally, brothers and sisters, we beg and encourage you in the Lord
Jesus: you received instruction from us about the way you must live
to please God (and you do live that way); now excel even more. 2 For
you know what instructions we gave you through the Lord Jesus. 3
For this is the will of God, your sanctification:[a] that you abstain from
sexual immorality; 4 that each of you learn to master his own body[b]
in a holy and respectful way, 5 not with lustful passion as the Gentiles
have, who know nothing of God; 6 and that no one transgress against
and wrong his brother in this matter, because the Lord is an avenger
in all these things,[c] as we told you before and solemnly warned you. 7
God called us not for uncleanness but to be holy. 8 So whoever rejects
this rejects not a human being but God, who gives his Holy Spirit
to you.[d]

9 As for love among believers, there is no need for anyone to write to
you, since you have been taught by God himself to love each other.
10 And you are in fact doing so toward all the brothers in the whole
of Macedonia. Still, brothers, we urge you to excel in it even more, 11
and to aim at a quiet life, attending to your own business and earning
your living by the work of your own hands, just as we told you, 12 so
that your conduct will win the respect of outsiders and you will lack
nothing.

13 Friends, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who
have fallen asleep in death,[e] so that you will not grieve like everyone
else, who has no hope. 14 For since we believe that Jesus died and rose
again, so too through Jesus God will bring with him those who have
fallen asleep.[f] 15 For this we declare to you by a word of the Lord:
we who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, will
by no means go ahead of those who have fallen asleep. 16 The Lord
himself will descend from heaven with a shout of command, with
an archangel’s voice, and with God’s trumpet, and those who died
in Christ will rise first.[g] 17 Then we who are alive, who are left, will

be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.[h] 18 So encourage one another with these words.

Notes

- a (4:3) Sanctification: Greek *hagiasmos*, being made holy; also in verses 4 and 7.
- b (4:4) Gain control over his own body: literally "acquire his own vessel." *Vessel* may mean one's own body, or, as some interpret it, a wife ("take a wife for himself").
- c (4:6) The Lord is an avenger: an echo of Ps 94:1 (93:1 in the Greek Old Testament), "God of vengeance, Yahweh," and of Deut 32:35. Here *Lord* probably refers to Jesus as judge.
- d (4:8) Gives his Holy Spirit to you: an echo of Ezek 36:27; 37:14 in the Greek Old Testament.
- e (4:13) Asleep in death: literally "sleeping," a common euphemism for death; so also "fallen asleep" in verses 14–15.
- f (4:14) Through Jesus: these words may go with "fallen asleep" ("those who have fallen asleep through Jesus," that is, as believers) or, as here, with "bring."
- g (4:16) Trumpet: in the Old Testament the trumpet announces the coming of God and the gathering of his people (Exod 19:16; Isa 27:13; Joel 2:1; Zech 9:14).
- h (4:17) To meet: Greek *eis apantēsin*, used of a delegation going out from a city to welcome an arriving dignitary and escort him back.

Chapter 5

1 Now concerning the times and the seasons, brothers, you have no need for anything to be written to you. 2 You know perfectly well yourselves that the day of the Lord[a] is coming the way a thief comes by night. 3 When they are saying, "All is peaceful and secure,"[b] ruin will come on them all at once, like birth pains on a woman with child, and there will be no escape for them. 4 You, though, brothers, are not living in the dark, so that the day should catch you unawares as daylight catches thieves.[c] 5 Every one of you is a child of light and a child of the day.[d] We are not of the night, nor of the darkness. 6 So we must not sleep like everyone else, but stay alert and keep our heads clear. 7 Sleepers sleep by night, and drinkers get drunk by night. 8 But because we belong to the day, let us keep clear heads, protected by the breastplate of faith and love and wearing the hope of salvation as a helmet.[e] 9 God did not appoint us to suffer wrath; he appointed us to win salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ. 10 He died for us so

that, awake or asleep, we may live together with him. 11 So comfort
each other and strengthen each other, as indeed you already do.
12 We ask you, brothers, to respect those who labor among you, who
lead you in the Lord and admonish you, 13 and to esteem them very
highly in love because of their work. Be at peace among yourselves. 14
We appeal to you, brothers: warn those who are out of line,[f] cheer up
the discouraged, hold on to the weak, and be patient toward everyone.
15 See to it that no one returns harm for harm; rather, always aim at
what is good, for one another and for all. 16 Rejoice always, 17 pray
without ceasing, 18 whatever happens, give thanks; this is what God
wills for you in Christ Jesus. 19 Do not quench the Spirit. 20 Do not
despise prophecies, 21 but test everything; hold fast what is good. 22
Abstain from every form of evil.
23 Now may the God of peace himself sanctify you completely, and
may your spirit and soul and body be kept whole and blameless at the
coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. 24 The one calling you can be trusted,
and he will do it.
25 Brothers, pray for us also. 26 Greet all the brothers with a holy kiss.
27 By the Lord I charge you to have this letter read aloud to every
brother and sister.[g] 28 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.[h]

Notes

- a (5:2) The day of the Lord: in the Old Testament, the day of Yahweh, when God comes to judge and to save (Amos 5:18–20; Joel 2:31; Zeph 1:14–18); here applied to the coming of the Lord Jesus.
- b (5:3) All is peaceful and secure: literally “peace and security,” perhaps a slogan of Roman imperial propaganda (Latin *pax et securitas*); compare also Jer 6:14.
- c (5:4) As daylight catches thieves: literally “like thieves,” the reading of the Westcott–Hort text, with Alexandrinus and Vaticanus as reported. Many manuscripts read “like a thief,” as in verse 2.
- d (5:5) Child: literally “son,” a Hebrew idiom for one marked by something.
- e (5:8) Compare Isa 59:17.
- f (5:14) Out of line: Greek *ataktoi*, “disorderly,” traditionally “idle,” perhaps those who had stopped working (compare 4:11; 2 Thess 3:6–12).
- g (5:27) Every brother and sister: literally “all the brothers”; later manuscripts read “all the holy brothers.”
- h (5:28) Later manuscripts add “Amen.”

2 Thessalonians

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] Silvanus[b] and Timothy,[c] to the Thessalonians' church,[d] which
is in God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ:[e] 2 grace and peace be
yours from God the Father[f] and the Lord Jesus Christ.
3 We are bound to thank God for you at all times, brothers,[g] and rightly
so, because your faith is growing beyond measure, and the love that
every one of you has for one another keeps on increasing. 4 So we
ourselves boast about you among God's churches, telling of your
endurance and faith through all the persecutions and troubles you are
bearing. 5 This is evidence of God's just judgment, and its purpose is
that you should be counted worthy of God's kingdom, for which you
are indeed suffering. 6 For it is surely just in God's eyes to repay with
trouble those who are troubling you, 7 and to grant rest to you who are
afflicted, and to us too, at the revealing of the Lord Jesus from heaven
with his powerful angels 8 in a blaze of fire,[h] dealing out vengeance
to those who have no knowledge of God and to those who will not
heed the good news[i] of our Lord Jesus. 9 These will pay the penalty
of everlasting ruin, shut out from the face of the Lord and from the
glory of his might,[j] 10 on that day when he comes to be glorified in his
holy ones and to be marveled at among all who have believed; and
you are among them, because you believed our testimony.[k]
11 With this in view we pray for you constantly, asking our God to
make you worthy of his calling and by his power to bring to comple-
tion every desire you have for goodness and every work that faith
produces, 12 so that our Lord Jesus' name will be honored through
you, and you through him, according to the grace of our God and the
Lord Jesus Christ.[l]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, “small.” Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel (“asked for”).
- b (1:1) *Silvanus*: Latin, “of the forest,” the Roman form of the name *Silas* (Acts 15:40; 17:4).
- c (1:1) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, “one who honors God.”
- d (1:1) Thessalonians: the people of Thessalonica, the capital of the Roman province of Macedonia (see 1 Thess 1:1).
- e (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), “Yahweh saves.” *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, “Anointed One,” equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, “Messiah.”
- f (1:2) God the Father: some manuscripts read “God our Father.”
- g (1:3) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women; so throughout.
- h (1:8) In a blaze of fire: literally “in a fire of flame,” echoing Isa 66:15 and Exod 3:2. Some manuscripts read “in flaming fire.”
- i (1:8) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally “gospel”; so throughout.
- j (1:9) From the face of the Lord and from the glory of his might: words from Isa 2:10, 19, 21 in the Greek Old Testament, where the Hebrew has “from before the terror of Yahweh and from the splendor of his majesty.”
- k (1:10) Glorified in his holy ones … that day: echoing Ps 89:7 (88:8 in the Greek Old Testament) and Isa 2:11, 17, where the glory and the day belong to Yahweh.
- l (1:12) So that the name … may be glorified: echoing Isa 66:5 in the Greek Old Testament. *Our God and the Lord Jesus Christ*: or “our God and Lord, Jesus Christ.” Because “Lord” lacks the article in Greek, a few interpreters take both titles to refer to Jesus (compare Titus 2:13); but “Lord Jesus Christ” often occurs without the article, and most take the phrase to name God and Jesus separately.

Chapter 2

1 Now, brothers, concerning the coming[a] of our Lord Jesus Christ and
our being gathered together to him, we ask you 2 not to be quickly
shaken in your thinking or alarmed, whether by a spirit, or by a
spoken word, or by a letter supposed to be from us, claiming that
the day of the Lord has already arrived.[b] 3 Do not let anyone lead
you astray in any way. That day will not come unless the rebellion[c]
happens first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the one destined
for destruction.[d] 4 He is the adversary who lifts himself up over
everything that people call a god or venerate, until he goes so far as
to sit down in God’s temple and display himself as being God.[e] 5 Do
you not remember that I kept telling you these things when I was still
with you? 6 And you know what is holding him back now, so that he

will be revealed at his proper time. 7 For the secret[f] of lawlessness is
already at work; only the one who now holds it back will do so until
he is taken out of the way.[g] 8 Then the lawless one will be exposed,
and the Lord[h] will destroy him by the breath from his mouth and put
an end to him at the brightness of his arrival.[i] 9 The coming of the
lawless one is by the working of Satan,[j] with all power and with signs
and wonders that serve the lie, 10 and with every kind of unrighteous
trickery aimed at the perishing, who would not welcome a love for
the truth that would have saved them. 11 For this reason God sends
them a power that leads them astray, so that they believe what is false,
12 in order that all who have not believed the truth but have delighted
in wickedness may be condemned.
13 But we are bound to thank God for you always, brothers loved by
the Lord, because God chose you from the beginning[k] to be saved,
through the Spirit's work of making you holy and through your
faith in the truth. 14 To this he called you through our good news,
so that you might obtain the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ. 15 So
then, brothers, stand firm and hold on to the traditions that you were
taught by us, whether by word of mouth or by our letter.
16 Now may our Lord Jesus Christ himself, and God our Father, who
loved us and by grace gave us eternal encouragement and good hope,
17 encourage your hearts and strengthen them in every good work
and word.

Notes

- a (2:1) Coming: Greek *parousia*, "presence," "arrival," used of the visit of a ruler; also in verses 8 and 9.
- b (2:2) The day of the Lord: in the Old Testament, the day of Yahweh, when God comes to judge and to save (Amos 5:18–20; Joel 2:31); here applied to the coming of the Lord Jesus. Later manuscripts read "the day of Christ." *By a spirit*: that is, by a prophetic utterance.
- c (2:3) Rebellion: Greek *apostasia*, "revolt," "falling away."
- d (2:3) Man of lawlessness: many manuscripts read "man of sin." *The one destined for destruction*: literally "the son of destruction," a Hebrew idiom.
- e (2:4) Compare Dan 11:36; Ezek 28:2.
- f (2:7) Secret: Greek *mystērion*, traditionally "mystery," here the hidden working of lawlessness.

- g (2:7) The one who now holds it back: Greek *ho katechōn* (masculine), following *to katechon* (neuter), "what is holding him back," in verse 6. Paul's readers knew what he meant (verse 5), but it is unknown today. Suggestions include the Roman empire and its emperor, the preaching of the good news and Paul himself, an angel, or God's own restraint.
- h (2:8) The Lord: the Westcott–Hort text adds "Jesus" in brackets, with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus as reported.
- i (2:8) Slay with the breath of his mouth: from Isa 11:4, where the shoot of Jesse "will kill the wicked with the breath of his lips." Some manuscripts read "consume" for "slay." *Splendor*: Greek *epiphaneia*, "appearing," "manifestation."
- j (2:9) Satan: Hebrew, "adversary," "accuser."
- k (2:13) From the beginning: some manuscripts, reportedly including Vaticanus, read *aparchēn*, "as firstfruits," instead of *ap' archēs*, "from the beginning."

Chapter 3

1 Finally, brothers, pray for us, that the word of the Lord may spread
swiftly and be honored, as it was among you,[a] 2 and that we will be
delivered from twisted and wicked people, since not everyone has
faith. 3 Yet the Lord keeps faith: he will make you firm and protect you
from the evil one.[b] 4 Our trust in the Lord concerning you is that you
are carrying out our instructions now and will keep carrying them
out. 5 May the Lord direct your hearts to the love of God and to the
endurance of Christ.

6 We command you, brothers and sisters, in the name of the Lord Jesus
Christ, to stay away from any believer who lives in idleness[c] and not
by the teaching they received from us.[d] 7 You know well enough how
to follow our example: there was nothing idle in our conduct while we
lived among you. 8 We did not take free meals from anybody; we toiled
and labored, working night and day, so that we would be a burden
to none of you. 9 Not that we lack the right to support; we wanted to
make ourselves a pattern for you to copy. 10 Even while we were with
you, we gave you this rule: anyone unwilling to work should not eat.
11 For we hear that some among you are living in idleness, not busy at
work but busybodies.[e] 12 Such people we instruct and appeal to in the
Lord Jesus Christ: let them settle down to their work quietly and eat
bread they have earned.[f] 13 But you, brothers, must never tire of doing
what is right. 14 Should anyone refuse to heed our word in this letter,

mark him out and keep apart from him, so that he will feel shame. 15
Yet do not treat him as a foe; admonish him as you would a brother.
16 Now may the Lord of peace himself give you peace at all times and
in every way. The Lord be with you all.
17 This greeting is in my own handwriting: Paul. It is the sign of
genuineness in all my letters; this is my hand.[g] 18 The grace of our
Lord Jesus Christ be with you all.[h]

Notes

- a (3:1) Spread swiftly: literally "run"; compare Ps 147:15 (147:4 in the Greek Old Testament).
- b (3:3) The evil one: or "evil."
- c (3:6) In idleness: Greek *ataktōs*, "in a disorderly way," "out of line"; also in verses 7 and 11. The context shows that the disorder was a refusal to work.
- d (3:6) They received: some manuscripts read "you received."
- e (3:11) Not busy … busybodies: a wordplay in Greek, *mēden ergazomenous alla periergazomenous*.
- f (3:12) Eat bread they have earned: literally "eat their own bread."
- g (3:17) Paul usually dictated his letters to a scribe and added a closing in his own handwriting (1 Cor 16:21; Gal 6:11; Col 4:18).
- h (3:18) Later manuscripts add "Amen."

1 Timothy

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] apostle[b] of Christ Jesus under orders from God our Savior and
from Christ Jesus, who is our hope,[c] 2 to Timothy,[d] his true son in
the faith: grace, mercy, peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus
our Lord.
3 As I was leaving for Macedonia,[e] I asked you to remain in Ephesus[f]
so you could instruct certain individuals to quit teaching a different
doctrine 4 and to stop occupying themselves with myths and with
genealogies that go on without end. These breed speculation rather
than God's ordering of things,[g] which is known by faith. 5 The aim of
that charge is love, springing from a clean heart, a good conscience
and faith without pretense. 6 Some have missed the mark here and
wandered off into empty talk. 7 They want to be teachers of the law,
yet they have no understanding either of the words they use or of the
matters they insist on so confidently.
8 Now we know that the law is a fine thing, provided it is used
lawfully, 9 with this understanding: law is not laid down for an upright
person but for those who flout law and will not be ruled, for the
godless and sinful, for the unholy and profane, for those who strike
their fathers or mothers, for murderers, 10 the sexually immoral, men
who lie with males,[h] kidnappers,[i] liars, perjurers, and whatever else
stands opposed to healthy teaching, 11 in keeping with the glorious
good news[j] of the blessed God, which was entrusted to me.
12 I thank Christ Jesus our Lord, who has empowered me, because he
considered me faithful and placed me in his service, 13 though in time
past I was a blasphemer, a persecutor and a man of violence. But I
was shown mercy, because I acted in ignorance, in unbelief, 14 and the
grace of our Lord overflowed beyond measure, together with the faith
and love that are in Christ Jesus. 15 Here is a saying to be trusted and

worthy of complete acceptance:[k] Christ Jesus came into the world to
save sinners. And of these I am the foremost. 16 Yet this is exactly why
mercy was shown me: Christ Jesus meant to make me, the chief of
sinners, the first showcase of all his patience, a pattern for those who
would later put their trust in him and gain life everlasting. 17 To the
eternal King, the immortal, unseen, only God,[l] be honor and glory
forever and ever. Amen.
18 This charge I commit to you, Timothy my son, in line with the
prophecies once spoken about you, so that by their help you may
fight the good fight,[m] 19 holding on to faith and a good conscience. By
thrusting conscience aside, some have made shipwreck of their faith.
20 Hymenaeus and Alexander[n] are among them, and I have turned
them over to Satan[o] so that discipline will teach them not to slander
God.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, "one sent," a messenger or envoy.
- c (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah."
- d (1:2) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, "one who honors God."
- e (1:3) Macedonia: the Roman province in northern Greece.
- f (1:3) Ephesus: the chief city of the Roman province of Asia, on the western coast of modern Turkey.
- g (1:4) God's ordering of things: Greek *oikonomia theou*, "God's household management," that is, his plan or arrangement; some manuscripts read *oikodomēn*, "God's building up."
- h (1:10) Men who lie with males: Greek *arsenokoitai*, a rare compound of "male" and "bed," apparently drawn from Lev 18:22 and 20:13 in the Greek Old Testament; compare 1 Cor 6:9. Its precise range of meaning is debated.
- i (1:10) Kidnappers: or "slave traders," those who seize people to sell them.
- j (1:11) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally "gospel"; so throughout.
- k (1:15) A saying to be trusted: literally "faithful is the word," a formula found in these letters (3:1; 4:9; 2 Tim 2:11; Titus 3:8) to introduce or confirm a saying.
- l (1:17) The only God: later manuscripts read "the only wise God."
- m (1:18) Fight the good fight: literally "wage the good warfare."
- n (1:20) *Hymenaeus*: Greek, named after Hymen, the god of weddings; compare 2 Tim 2:17. *Alexander*: Greek, "defender of men"; perhaps the man of 2 Tim 4:14.

- o (1:20) Satan: Hebrew, “adversary,” “accuser.” *Handed over to Satan*: compare 1 Cor 5:5; probably exclusion from the church’s fellowship.

Chapter 2

1 My first request, then, is this: let petitions, prayers, pleas and
thanksgivings be made for everyone,
2 for kings and all who hold high positions, so that we may lead a
peaceful and quiet life in all godliness and dignity.
3 This is good, and pleasing in the sight of God our Savior,
4 whose will is that all people be saved and come to know the truth.
5 For there is one God,
and one mediator also between God and humankind,
the man Christ Jesus,
6 who offered himself as a ransom on behalf of all,
the witness borne at the right moment.[a]
7 For this I was appointed a herald and an apostle (I speak the truth,
I am not lying),[b] a teacher of the Gentiles in faith and truth.
8 So I want the men everywhere to pray, raising holy hands, without
anger or quarreling. 9 Likewise the women should adorn themselves
in fitting dress, with modesty and good sense, not with braided hair
and gold or pearls[c] or costly clothes, 10 but with what suits women who
profess reverence for God, namely good works. 11 A woman should
learn in quietness, in full submission. 12 I do not permit a woman to
teach or to domineer over a man;[d] she is to remain quiet. 13 For Adam
was formed first, and Eve after him.[e] 14 And Adam was not the one
deceived; the woman was deceived and became a transgressor.[f] 15 Yet
she will be saved through childbearing, if they continue in faith and
love and holiness, with good sense.[g]

Notes

- a (2:6) The testimony given at the proper time: literally “the testimony in its own times.” Verses 5–6 may quote an early confession; the setting as verse here is editorial.
- b (2:7) I speak the truth: later manuscripts add “in Christ.”
- c (2:9) Pearls: in the ancient world among the costliest of gems.
- d (2:12) Domineer over: Greek *authentein*, found only here in the New Testament. Its sense is debated: “have authority over,” “assume authority over,” or “dominate.”

A woman ... a man: or “a wife ... her husband”; the same Greek words serve for both.

- e (2:13) *Adam*: Hebrew, “human being,” related to *adamah*, “ground” (Gen 2:7). *Eve*: Hebrew *Chawwah*, “living” (Gen 3:20).
- f (2:14) Compare Gen 3:13.
- g (2:15) Saved through childbearing: the meaning is much debated. Proposals include being kept safe in childbirth; being saved through the birth of the Messiah (compare Gen 3:15); or being saved while fulfilling an ordinary role as wife and mother. *They*: probably women generally, or the women and their children.

Chapter 3

1 Here is a trustworthy saying:[a] whoever sets his heart on being an
overseer[b] is longing for a fine task. 2 An overseer, then, must be above
reproach, the husband of one wife,[c] clear-headed, self-controlled,
orderly, hospitable, able to teach, 3 not a heavy drinker,[d] not a brawler
but gentle, not quarrelsome, free from the love of money. 4 He should
govern his own home well and have children who obey him with all
proper respect. 5 If someone cannot govern his own home, how can
he look after the church of God? 6 He should not be newly converted,[e]
in case pride goes to his head and he falls into the condemnation that
came on the devil.[f] 7 He must also be well thought of by outsiders, so
that he does not fall into disgrace and into the devil’s trap.
8 Deacons[g] likewise must be worthy of respect, not double-tongued,
not addicted to much wine, not out for shameful gain. 9 They must
hold the secret[h] of the faith with a clear conscience. 10 And they too
should first be tested; then, if no charge can be brought against them,
let them serve as deacons. 11 Women, likewise,[i] must be worthy of
respect, not slanderers, clear-headed, faithful in everything. 12 Each
deacon is to be the husband of one wife and to govern his children
and his home well. 13 Those who serve well in this office win for
themselves an honorable rank and much confidence in the faith that
rests in Christ Jesus.
14 Though I expect to be with you soon, I am sending you these
instructions
15 so that, should I be held up, you may know what conduct befits
those in God’s house, the church of the living God, which upholds
the truth as a pillar and a base.

16 And beyond all question great is the secret of our godliness:
He who was made visible in the flesh,[j]
was vindicated in the Spirit,[k]
was seen by angels,
was proclaimed among the nations,
was believed in throughout the world,
was taken up in glory.

Notes

- a (3:1) A trustworthy saying: some manuscripts read "a human saying," perhaps meaning "a common saying."
- b (3:1) Overseer: Greek *episkopos*, "one who watches over," traditionally "bishop." In these letters the overseers appear to be the same as the elders (compare Titus 1:5–7).
- c (3:2) The husband of one wife: literally "a man of one woman." This may forbid polygamy, remarriage after divorce or after a spouse's death, or unfaithfulness; the precise sense is debated. So also in verse 12.
- d (3:3) Not a heavy drinker: literally "not given to wine."
- e (3:6) Newly converted: Greek *neophytos*, "newly planted."
- f (3:6) The devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer"; so also in verse 7. *The condemnation that came on the devil*: or "the condemnation the devil brings."
- g (3:8) Deacons: Greek *diakonoi*, "servants," "ministers"; here church officers.
- h (3:9) Secret: Greek *mystērion*, traditionally "mystery"; so also in verse 16.
- i (3:11) Women: or "wives," that is, the deacons' wives; or women who serve as deacons (compare Rom 16:1).
- j (3:16) He who: so the earliest manuscripts, reportedly including Sinaiticus before correction, Alexandrinus and Ephraemi before correction (Greek *hos*). Some manuscripts read "which" (*ho*), agreeing with "secret." Later manuscripts read "God" (*theos*), a change easily made in Greek manuscripts, where *hos* (ΟΣ) and the abbreviation for *theos* (ΘΣ) differ by two small strokes. The lines that follow are widely thought to quote an early hymn; the setting as verse is editorial.
- k (3:16) Vindicated in the Spirit: or "justified by the Spirit," or "shown to be righteous in spirit."

Chapter 4

1 Now the Spirit says in plain words that in later times some will desert the faith, giving heed to spirits that lead astray and to teachings that come from demons, 2 through the hypocrisy of liars whose consciences have been seared as with a branding iron. 3 They prohibit marrying and insist that people keep away from foods, which God

made to be shared with thanks by those who have faith and have
come to know the truth. 4 For all that God made is good, and nothing
should be refused when it is accepted with thanks, 5 since God's word
and prayer consecrate it.
6 By pointing out these things to the believers,[a] you will be an
excellent servant of Christ Jesus, fed on the message of the faith and
the sound teaching you have followed closely. 7 But have nothing to
do with profane myths fit only for old women. Train yourself for
godliness instead.[b] 8 Bodily training has some little value; godliness
has value in every way, holding promise for the present life and for
the life to come. 9 This saying is to be trusted and worthy of complete
acceptance. 10 That is why we toil and struggle,[c] because we have set
our hope on the living God, who is the Savior of all people, especially
of those who believe.
11 Give these instructions and teach them. 12 Do not let anyone think
little of you because you are young.[d] Instead, be a pattern for the
faithful in what you say and how you live, in love, faith and purity.
13 Till I arrive, give your attention to reading Scripture aloud,[e] to
exhorting and to teaching. 14 Do not neglect the gift that is in you,
which was given to you through prophecy when the council of elders[f]
laid their hands on you. 15 Make these things your care and your whole
occupation, so that your advance is evident to everyone. 16 Keep a
close watch on yourself and on your teaching; persist in these things,
for by doing so you will save both yourself and those who listen to
you.

Notes

- a (4:6) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, the usual term for fellow believers, including both men and women.
- b (4:7) Train: Greek *gymnaze*, from the word for athletic exercise; so also "training" in verse 8.
- c (4:10) Struggle: some manuscripts read "suffer reproach."
- d (4:12) Young: in Greek usage the term for youth could cover adults up to about forty.
- e (4:13) Reading Scripture aloud: literally "the reading," that is, reading aloud in the assembly.
- f (4:14) Council of elders: Greek *presbyterion*, the body of elders (*presbyteroi*).

Chapter 5

1 Never harshly criticize an older man, but urge him as though he
were your father. Treat younger men like brothers, 2 elderly women
as you would mothers, and young women as sisters, with complete
purity.
3 Honor widows who are truly in need.[a] 4 But if a widow has children
or grandchildren, they should first learn to practice their religion at
home and to repay their parents, since this pleases God.[b] 5 A real
widow, one left on her own, has put her hope in God and continues
day and night in petitions and prayers. 6 But a widow who gives
herself to luxury is dead though she is alive. 7 Give these instructions
too, so that they may be beyond reproach. 8 Anyone who does not
provide for his own relatives, and especially for members of his
household, has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.
9 Let a widow be put on the list only if she is not under sixty years of
age and has been the wife of one husband,[c] 10 and is known for good
works: if she has brought up children, if she has shown hospitality,
if she has washed the feet of God's people,[d] if she has helped the
afflicted, if she has devoted herself to every kind of good work. 11 But
refuse to enroll younger widows, for when their desires draw them
away from Christ, they want to marry, 12 and so they incur condem-
nation for having set aside their first pledge.[e] 13 They also pick up
the habit of being idle and wandering from house to house; and they
become not merely idle but also gossips and meddlers, who say things
they should not. 14 So I would have younger widows marry, bear
children, manage their homes, and give the adversary no opening for
abuse. 15 For some have already turned aside to follow Satan. 16 If any
believing woman has widows in her family,[f] she should assist them,
and the church should not be burdened, so that it can assist those
who are truly widows in need.
17 Elders who lead well should be considered worthy of a double
honor,[g] especially those who labor in preaching and teaching. 18
Scripture says, "Do not muzzle an ox as it threshes,"[h] and, "The laborer
has earned his pay."[i] 19 Do not entertain a charge brought against an
elder unless two or three witnesses bear it out.[j] 20 Any who keep on

sinning you should reprove publicly, so that the others will be afraid.
21 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the chosen
angels to keep these rules without prejudging anyone, doing nothing
out of partiality. 22 Do not rush to ordain anyone,[k] and do not take
part in the sins of others. Keep yourself pure. 23 Stop drinking water
alone; use a little wine because of your stomach and the illnesses you
so often have. 24 Some people's sins are plain to see, going ahead of
them to judgment, but the sins of others follow after them. 25 So too
good works are plain to see, and those that are not cannot remain
hidden.

Notes

- a (5:3) Honor: the word may include financial support; so also "honor" in verse 17.
- b (5:4) Pleasing: later manuscripts read "good and pleasing."
- c (5:9) The wife of one husband: literally "a woman of one man"; compare 3:2.
- d (5:10) God's people: literally "the holy ones," traditionally "the saints." Washing the feet of guests was a menial act of hospitality (John 13:14).
- e (5:12) First pledge: literally "first faith," probably a pledge to remain unmarried in the service of Christ.
- f (5:16) Believing woman: later manuscripts read "believing man or woman."
- g (5:17) Elders: Greek *presbyteroi*, the leaders of the congregation; in verse 1 the same word means simply "older man." *Double honor*: probably including payment; compare verse 18.
- h (5:18) Do not muzzle an ox as it threshes: Deut 25:4; compare 1 Cor 9:9. Oxen were driven over the harvested grain to loosen the kernels.
- i (5:18) The laborer has earned his pay: a saying of Jesus, found in Luke 10:7 and in a slightly different form in Matt 10:10. Here it is cited alongside Scripture.
- j (5:19) Compare Deut 19:15.
- k (5:22) Laying hands on: that is, appointing someone to office (4:14), or possibly restoring someone who has sinned.

Chapter 6

1 Let all who are under the yoke as slaves regard their own masters
as deserving all honor, so that the name of God and the teaching
may not be spoken against. 2 Those who have believing masters must
not think less of them because they are brothers; rather, they should
serve them all the better, since those who benefit from their good
service are believers and dear to God.[a] Teach and urge these things. 3
If anyone teaches a different doctrine and does not hold to the healthy

words of our Lord Jesus Christ and to the teaching that accords with godliness, 4 he is swollen with conceit and understands nothing. He has a sick craving for controversies and quarrels about words, from which come envy, strife, slander, evil suspicions, 5 and constant friction among people who are corrupted in mind and robbed of the truth, who imagine that godliness is a means of gain.[b] 6 There is indeed great gain in godliness combined with contentment. 7 For we brought nothing into the world, and so we can take nothing out of it.[c] 8 Having food and clothing,[d] we will be satisfied with that. 9 People who want to be rich, however, tumble into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and hurtful cravings that drag them down into ruin and destruction. 10 For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil,[e] and some, in reaching for it, have wandered from the faith and pierced themselves through with many pangs.

11 But you, man of God, flee from these things. Pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, gentleness. 12 Fight the good fight[f] of the faith; take hold of the eternal life to which you were called when you made the good confession in the presence of many witnesses. 13 I charge you in the sight of God, who gives life to all things, and of Christ Jesus, who made the good confession in his testimony before Pontius Pilate,[g] 14 to keep the commandment spotless and blameless until the appearing[h] of our Lord Jesus Christ, 15 This he will make manifest in his own good time, he the blessed and sole Ruler, the King of kings and Lord of lords,[i] 16 who alone is immortal, living in light no one can approach, whom no human eye has ever seen or is able to see. His be the honor and the everlasting power. Amen.

17 Those who are rich in this present world you must instruct not to think too highly of themselves and not to pin their hopes on wealth, which is so uncertain, but on God, who gives us all things in abundance for our enjoyment. 18 Tell them to do good, to grow rich in fine deeds, to give freely and share with others, 19 and so lay up treasure for themselves as a sound foundation for what is to come, in order to grasp the life that is real life.

20 Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you. Turn away from godless chatter and the contradictions of what is falsely called knowl-

edge,[j] 21 which some have professed and so have missed the mark concerning the faith. Grace be with you all.[k]

Notes

- a (6:2) Those who benefit from their good service: or “those who devote themselves to good service,” referring to the masters. *Dear to God*: literally “beloved.”
- b (6:5) Later manuscripts add “From such people withdraw.”
- c (6:7) And so: the Greek is awkward, literally “that.” Later manuscripts read “and it is clear that.” Compare Job 1:21; Eccl 5:15.
- d (6:8) Clothing: or “shelter”; the Greek word means “coverings.”
- e (6:10) A root of all kinds of evil: or “the root of all evils.”
- f (6:12) Fight the good fight: literally “contend in the good contest,” an image from athletic competition.
- g (6:13) *Pontius Pilate*: the Roman governor of Judea, AD 26–36, under whom Jesus was crucified. *Pilate*: Latin *Pilatus*, perhaps “armed with a javelin.”
- h (6:14) Appearing: Greek *epiphaneia*, “appearance,” “manifestation.”
- i (6:15) King of kings and Lord of lords: literally “the King of those who reign and Lord of those who rule”; compare Deut 10:17; Rev 17:14; 19:16.
- j (6:20) Knowledge: Greek *gnōsis*. Later groups claiming special knowledge were called “Gnostics,” but whether such teaching is in view here is uncertain.
- k (6:21) With you all: the “you” is plural. Later manuscripts read “with you” (singular) and add “Amen.”

2 Timothy

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] by God's will an apostle[b] of Christ Jesus, sent to make known
the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus,[c] 2 to Timothy,[d] my dearly
loved son: grace, mercy, peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus
our Lord.
3 I give thanks to God, whom I serve with a clean conscience as my
forebears did, as I keep you in mind without ceasing in my prayers
by night and by day. 4 I remember the tears you shed, and I yearn
to see you again, so that my joy may be complete. 5 I am reminded
of the unfeigned faith that is in you, a faith that lived first in your
grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice,[e] and that I am convinced
lives in you as well. 6 For this reason I urge you to rekindle the gift
of God that came to you when I placed my hands on you. 7 For the
spirit God gave us is not one of cowardice; it is a spirit of power, of
love and of self-discipline.[f]
8 So never be ashamed of bearing witness to our Lord, nor of me his
prisoner. Instead, take your share of hardship for the good news,[g]
relying on the power of God, 9 who rescued us and called us with a
holy calling, not on the basis of anything we had done, but because
of his own purpose and the grace he bestowed on us in Christ
Jesus before time began,[h] 10 and now it has been made plain by the
appearing[i] of Christ Jesus our Savior, who has put an end to death's
power and, by the good news, shed light on life and immortality. 11
for which I have been appointed herald, apostle and teacher.[j] 12 That
is why I endure these sufferings. But I feel no shame, because I know
whom I have trusted, and I am persuaded that what I have placed in
his keeping he can guard until that day.[k] 13 Hold to the wholesome
words you heard from me as a model, living in the faith and love that

are ours in Christ Jesus. 14 Through the Holy Spirit, who dwells in us,
keep safe the fine treasure committed to your care.
15 You know that all the believers in Asia[l] have abandoned me, including Phygelus and Hermogenes.[m] 16 May the Lord show mercy to the household of Onesiphorus,[n] for he often refreshed me and was not ashamed of my chains. 17 On the contrary, when he arrived in Rome, he searched hard for me and found me. 18 The Lord grant that he finds mercy with the Lord on that day! How much he did for me in Ephesus you already know better than anyone.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, “small.” Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel (“asked for”).
- b (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, “one sent,” a messenger or envoy.
- c (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), “Yahweh saves.” *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, “Anointed One,” equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, “Messiah.”
- d (1:2) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, “one who honors God.”
- e (1:5) *Lois*: Greek, perhaps “more desirable.” *Eunice*: Greek *Eunikē*, “good victory.” Compare Acts 16:1.
- f (1:7) The spirit God gave us: or “God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of power …”; the reference may be to the Holy Spirit or to a disposition he imparts. *Self-discipline*: or “sound judgment.”
- g (1:8) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally “gospel”; so throughout.
- h (1:9) Before time began: literally “before eternal times.”
- i (1:10) Appearing: Greek *epiphaneia*, “appearance,” “manifestation”; also in 4:1 and 4:8.
- j (1:11) Teacher: later manuscripts add “of the Gentiles.”
- k (1:12) What I have placed in his keeping: or “what he has placed in my keeping”; literally “my deposit.” Compare verse 14.
- l (1:15) Asia: the Roman province in the west of modern Turkey, with Ephesus its chief city.
- m (1:15) *Phygelus*: Greek, perhaps “fugitive.” *Hermogenes*: Greek, “born of Hermes.”
- n (1:16) *Onesiphorus*: Greek, “bringer of benefit.”

Chapter 2

1 You, then, my son, draw your strength from the grace that is in
Christ Jesus. 2 What you heard from me in the presence of many
witnesses, pass on to reliable people who will be competent to teach

others as well. 3 Take your share of hardship[a] like a good soldier of
Christ Jesus. 4 No soldier on active duty gets entangled in the business
of civilian life; his aim is to please the officer who enlisted him. 5
Likewise an athlete is not crowned unless he competes by the rules.
6 The farmer who toils should be the first to eat from the harvest. 7
Think about what I am saying, for the Lord will give you insight into
everything.
8 Keep in mind Jesus Christ, raised from the dead, a descendant of
David,[b] as proclaimed in my good news,
9 It is for this good news that I suffer hardship, even to the point of
wearing chains like a wrongdoer. Yet the word of God is not in chains.
10 That is why I endure all things for the sake of God's chosen ones,
so that they also may gain the salvation found in Christ Jesus, along
with eternal glory.
11 Here is a saying to be trusted:[c]

If we have died with him, we shall also live with him;
12 if we endure, we shall also reign with him;
if we deny him, he also will deny us;
13 if we are faithless, he remains faithful,
for he cannot deny himself.

14 Keep reminding them of these things, and charge them in the sight
of God[d] not to wrangle over words, which does no good and only
brings ruin on those who listen. 15 Do your utmost to present yourself
to God as one approved, a worker with no cause for shame, cutting
a straight path with the word of truth.[e] 16 But steer clear of godless
chatter, for those who indulge in it will advance further and further
into ungodliness, 17 and their talk will eat its way like gangrene.
Hymenaeus and Philetus[f] are among them; 18 they have strayed from
the truth, claiming that the resurrection has already happened, and
they are overturning the faith of some. 19 Nevertheless God's firm
foundation stands, bearing this seal: "The Lord knows those who are
his,"[g] and, "Let everyone who names the name of the Lord turn away
from wickedness."[h]
20 In a great house there are utensils of gold and silver, and also
of wood and clay, some meant for special occasions and others for

ordinary use. 21 Anyone, then, who keeps himself clean of these will
be a vessel for noble use, consecrated, of service to the owner, fit for
any good task. 22 Flee the passions of youth, and pursue righteousness,
faith, love and peace, together with those who call on the Lord from a
pure heart. 23 Refuse to be drawn into stupid and uninstructed debates;
you know that they give birth to fights. 24 And a servant[i] of the Lord
must not be quarrelsome but kind toward all, able to teach, patient
when wronged, 25 gently instructing those who resist him. It may be
that God will give them a change of heart, so that they come to know
the truth, 26 and they may come to their senses and escape the devil's
snare, having been held captive by him to do his will.[j]

Notes

- a (2:3) Take your share of hardship: later manuscripts read "so endure hardship."
- b (2:8) A descendant of David: literally "from the seed of David." *David*: Hebrew, "beloved."
- c (2:11) A saying to be trusted: literally "faithful is the word"; compare 1 Tim 1:15. The lines that follow are widely thought to quote an early hymn or confession; the setting as verse is editorial.
- d (2:14) In the sight of God: some manuscripts read "in the sight of the Lord."
- e (2:15) Cutting a straight path with: Greek *orthotomounta*, literally "cutting straight," perhaps an image from road-building or plowing; that is, handling the word rightly.
- f (2:17) *Hymenaeus*: Greek, named after Hymen, the god of weddings; compare 1 Tim 1:20. *Philetus*: Greek, "beloved."
- g (2:19) The Lord knows those who are his: from Num 16:5 in the Greek Old Testament, where "the Lord" renders the divine name, Yahweh.
- h (2:19) Names the name of the Lord: echoing Isa 26:13 and the call to separate from the wicked in Num 16:26; in these passages "the Lord" stands for Yahweh.
- i (2:24) Servant: Greek *doulos*, "slave."
- j (2:26) The devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer." *Held captive by him to do his will*: or "held captive by the devil, so as to do God's will"; the Greek pronouns are ambiguous.

Chapter 3

1 Understand this: in the last days hard times will come. 2 For people
will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant,
abusive, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, 3 heartless,
unforgiving, slanderers, without self-control, brutal, haters of what

is good, [4] traitors, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, [5] keeping up an outward form of godliness but denying its power. Turn away from such people. [6] Some of these slip into people's homes and make captives of foolish women who are loaded down with sins and driven by various passions, [7] women who are forever learning yet can never reach a real understanding of the truth. [8] Just as Jannes and Jambres[a] opposed Moses, so these people oppose the truth, men corrupted in mind and disqualified in regard to the faith. [9] But they will not get much further, for their folly will be plain to everyone, as the folly of those two also became plain. [10] But you have closely followed what I taught, how I lived, what I aimed at, my faith, my patience, my love, my endurance, [11] my persecutions and sufferings, the things that happened to me at Antioch, at Iconium and at Lystra,[b] the persecutions I endured. Yet from all of them the Lord rescued me. [12] Indeed, everyone who sets out to live a devout life in Christ Jesus will meet persecution, [13] and evil people and swindlers will advance into worse and worse, leading others astray and being led astray themselves. [14] But as for you, hold on to what you have learned and become convinced of, knowing from whom you learned it,[c] [15] and that from childhood you have known the sacred writings, which can make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. [16] All Scripture is breathed out by God and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction and for training in righteousness,[d] [17] so that the person who belongs to God may be complete, equipped for every good work.

Notes

- a (3:8) *Jannes and Jambres*: names given in Jewish tradition to Pharaoh's magicians who opposed Moses (Exod 7:11, 22). *Moses*: Hebrew *Mosheh*, explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out."
- b (3:11) *Antioch* … *Iconium* … *Lystra*: cities in southern Asia Minor where Paul was persecuted (Acts 13:50; 14:5–6, 19). This Antioch, named after the Seleucid king Antiochus, lay near Pisidia; Lystra was Timothy's home town (Acts 16:1).
- c (3:14) From whom: the Greek is plural, "from which people," perhaps including Timothy's mother and grandmother (1:5). Later manuscripts read the singular.
- d (3:16) All Scripture is breathed out by God and useful: or "Every scripture breathed out by God is also useful." *Breathed out by God*: Greek *theopneustos*, "God-breathed," traditionally "inspired by God."

Chapter 4

1 I give you this solemn charge before God and Christ Jesus, who
will judge the living and the dead, and in view of his appearing and
his kingdom: 2 proclaim the word; be ready in season and out of
season; convince, rebuke and encourage, with unfailing patience and
teaching. 3 For a time is coming when people will not put up with
healthy teaching, but, with ears itching for something new, they will
heap up teachers for themselves to suit their own desires, 4 they will
stop listening to the truth and turn aside to fables instead. 5 But you,
keep your head in all circumstances, endure hardship, do the work of
an evangelist,[a] carry out your ministry to the full.
6 For my part, my life is already being poured out like a drink offering,[b]
and the moment of my departure is at hand. 7 I have fought the good
fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. 8 From now
on a crown of righteousness is waiting for me, which the Lord, the
righteous judge, will give me on that day, and not to me alone but to
everyone who has longed for his appearing.
9 Do your best to come to me soon. 10 Demas has abandoned me; he
loved the present age, and he has gone off to Thessalonica. Crescens
is away in Galatia,[c] Titus in Dalmatia.[d] 11 Only Luke is with me. Fetch
Mark and bring him along, because he is very useful to me for the
work.[e] 12 Tychicus I have sent to Ephesus.[f] 13 Bring with you, when
you come, the cloak I left in Troas at the house of Carpus,[g] and the
books too, especially the parchments.[h] 14 That coppersmith Alexander
treated me very badly; the Lord will requite him as his deeds deserve.[i]
15 You too should be on guard against him, for he strongly opposed
our message. 16 When I first defended myself, nobody came to my
support; all abandoned me. May it not be held against them! 17 But
the Lord stood beside me and made me strong, so that through me
the message would be preached in full and all the nations would hear
it. So I was snatched from the lion's mouth.[j] 18 The Lord will deliver
me from every wicked scheme and bring me safely to his heavenly
kingdom. Glory to him forever and ever. Amen.
19 Greet Prisca and Aquila,[k] and the household of Onesiphorus. 20
Erastus stayed in Corinth, and Trophimus I left ill at Miletus.[l] 21 Do

your best to come before winter.[m] Eubulus sends you greetings, as do Pudens, Linus, Claudia and all the brothers.[n]

22 The Lord be with your spirit.[o] Grace be with you all.[p]

Notes

- a (4:5) Evangelist: Greek *euangelistēs*, "one who brings good news."
- b (4:6) Drink offering: wine poured out as a sacrifice (Num 15:1–10; 28:7); compare Phil 2:17.
- c (4:10) *Demas*: Greek, probably short for *Demetrios*, "belonging to Demeter"; compare Col 4:14; Phlm 24. *Crescens*: Latin, "growing." *Galatia*: some manuscripts read "Gaul."
- d (4:10) *Titus*: Latin, of uncertain meaning. *Dalmatia*: a region on the eastern coast of the Adriatic Sea, in modern Croatia and its neighbors.
- e (4:11) *Luke*: Greek *Loukas*, probably from Latin *Lucius*, "light." *Mark*: Latin *Marcus*, perhaps from Mars, the Roman god of war; compare Acts 15:37–39; Col 4:10.
- f (4:12) *Tychicus*: Greek, "fortunate."
- g (4:13) *Carpus*: Greek, "fruit." *Troas*: a port in northwestern Asia Minor near ancient Troy.
- h (4:13) Books ... parchments: the books were probably papyrus scrolls; the parchments, writings on prepared animal skin, perhaps notebooks or copies of Scripture.
- i (4:14) *Alexander*: Greek, "defender of men"; compare 1 Tim 1:20. *The Lord will requite him as his deeds deserve*: echoing Ps 62:12 (61:13 in the Greek Old Testament) and Prov 24:12, where it is God, Yahweh, who repays each according to his deeds. Later manuscripts read "may the Lord requite him."
- j (4:17) The lion's mouth: a figure for deadly danger, echoing Ps 22:21 (21:22 in the Greek Old Testament); compare Dan 6:20–22.
- k (4:19) *Prisca*: Latin, "ancient," "venerable"; called *Priscilla* in Acts 18:2. *Aquila*: Latin, "eagle."
- l (4:20) *Erastus*: Greek, "beloved"; compare Acts 19:22; Rom 16:23. *Trophimus*: Greek, "nourishing"; compare Acts 20:4; 21:29. *Miletus*: a port on the coast of Asia, south of Ephesus.
- m (4:21) Before winter: sea travel on the Mediterranean largely stopped from about mid-November to March.
- n (4:21) *Eubulus*: Greek, "well-advised." *Pudens*: Latin, "modest." *Linus*: Greek, the name of a legendary singer; later tradition names a Linus as an early leader of the church in Rome. *Claudia*: Latin, feminine of *Claudius*. *Brothers*: Greek *adelphoi*, fellow believers, including both men and women. *All*: the Westcott–Hort text has "all" in brackets.
- o (4:22) The Lord: later manuscripts read "The Lord Jesus Christ."
- p (4:22) With you all: the "you" is plural. Later manuscripts add "Amen."

Titus

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] a servant[b] of God and an apostle[c] of Jesus Christ, sent to
further the faith of God's chosen ones and their grasp of the truth
that leads to godliness,[d] 2 resting on the hope of eternal life, which
God, who never lies, pledged before time began,[e] 3 and at the right
moment he made his message visible in the preaching entrusted to
me by command of God our Savior, 4 to Titus,[f] my genuine child in our
shared faith: grace and peace[g] from God the Father and from Christ
Jesus our Savior.
5 The reason I left you behind in Crete[h] was so that you would set
in order what still needed doing and appoint elders[i] in each town, as
I instructed you. 6 An elder must be blameless, the husband of one
wife,[j] with children who are believers[k] and are not open to the charge
of wild living or disobedience. 7 For an overseer,[l] as God's steward,
has to be beyond reproach: not headstrong, not hot-tempered, not a
drunkard, not violent, not grasping for gain, 8 but hospitable, a lover
of goodness, sensible, just, devout and self-controlled. 9 He must hold
firmly to the trustworthy message as it was taught, so that he can
both encourage others with healthy teaching and refute those who
speak against it.
10 For there are many who will not submit to authority, empty
talkers and deceivers, especially those of the circumcision party.[m] 11
They have to be silenced, for they are turning whole families upside
down by teaching for the sake of dishonest profit what they have
no business teaching. 12 One of them, a prophet of their own, has
said, "Cretans are liars forever, savage beasts, idle bellies."[n] 13 That
testimony is true. So reprove them sharply, so that they may be
healthy in the faith, 14 paying no attention to Jewish myths or to the
commands of people who reject the truth. 15 To the pure all things are

pure, but to the defiled and unbelieving nothing is pure; their very minds and consciences are defiled. 16 They profess to know God, yet their conduct disowns him; they are abhorrent and rebellious, and worthless for anything good.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, “small.” Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel (“asked for”).
- b (1:1) Servant: Greek *doulos*, “slave.”
- c (1:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, “one sent,” a messenger or envoy.
- d (1:1) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), “Yahweh saves.” *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, “Anointed One,” equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, “Messiah.”
- e (1:2) Before time began: literally “before eternal times.”
- f (1:4) *Titus*: Latin, of uncertain meaning. Titus was a Greek convert who worked closely with Paul (Gal 2:1–3; 2 Cor 8:23).
- g (1:4) Grace and peace: later manuscripts read “grace, mercy and peace.”
- h (1:5) Crete: the large island south of Greece in the Mediterranean Sea.
- i (1:5) Elders: Greek *presbyteroi*, the leaders of a congregation; in verse 7 the same people are called “overseers.”
- j (1:6) The husband of one wife: literally “a man of one woman”; compare 1 Tim 3:2. The precise sense is debated.
- k (1:6) Who are believers: or “who are faithful,” that is, trustworthy.
- l (1:7) Overseer: Greek *episkopos*, “one who watches over,” traditionally “bishop.”
- m (1:10) Those of the circumcision party: literally “those of the circumcision,” probably Jewish believers who insisted that Gentile converts be circumcised and keep the law.
- n (1:12) Cretans are liars forever …: a line traditionally attributed to the Cretan poet and seer Epimenides (about 600 BC). The first words, “Cretans always lie,” also appear in a hymn of Callimachus (3rd century BC).

Chapter 2

1 But as for you, speak what fits healthy teaching. 2 Older men are to be sober-minded, dignified, sensible, sound in faith, in love and in endurance. 3 In the same way, the older women should behave as befits the holy, not spreading slander and not in bondage to drink. They should be teachers of what is right, 4 and so train the young women to love their husbands and their children, 5 to be sensible, chaste, good managers of their homes,[a] kind, and submissive to their own husbands, so that the word of God may not be maligned. 6

Urge the younger men, too, to be sensible. 7 In every respect show
yourself a model of good works; in your teaching show integrity and
seriousness, 8 and sound words beyond criticism, so that whoever
stands against us may be put to shame for lack of anything evil to
say of us.[b] 9 Slaves are to be submissive to their own masters in
everything, to give satisfaction, not talking back, 10 not pilfering, but
showing complete and genuine reliability, so that in every way they
may adorn the teaching about God our Savior.
11 For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to all people,
12 It schools us to say no to impiety and to the cravings of this world,
and to live with self-control, justice and devotion in the age that now
is, 13 as we wait for the blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of
our great God and Savior, Christ Jesus.[c] 14 He gave himself for us to
set us free from all lawlessness and to cleanse for himself a people
who would be his own treasure, eager to do good works.[d] 15 Speak
about these things; urge and correct with full authority. Let no one
disregard you.

Notes

- a (2:5) Good managers of their homes: Greek *oikourgous*, “workers at home”; later manuscripts read *oikourous*, “keepers at home.”
- b (2:8) Us: later manuscripts read “you.”
- c (2:13) Our great God and Savior, Christ Jesus: or “the great God and our Savior Christ Jesus.” In Greek a single article governs both nouns (“the great God and Savior of us”), and by the rule known as Granville Sharp’s (after the English scholar who described it in 1798), two singular personal nouns joined by “and” under one article refer to the same person. On that reading Jesus is here called “God.” Others take the phrase to name two persons, God and Jesus, or render “the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, which is Christ Jesus.” *Appearing*: Greek *epiphaneia*, “appearance,” “manifestation.”
- d (2:14) To set us free … his own treasure: echoing Ps 130:8 and Ezek 37:23, and the phrase “a people for his own possession” in Exod 19:5 and Deut 7:6; 14:2 in the Greek Old Testament.

Chapter 3

1 Remind them to be subject to rulers and authorities, to be obedient,
to be ready for every good work, 2 to slander no one, to avoid
quarrels, to be gentle, and to show every courtesy to all people. 3

For we too were once foolish, disobedient and led astray, slaves to
all sorts of passions and pleasures, spending our days in malice and
envy, hateful and hating one another. 4 But when the kindness and
the love for humankind[a] of God our Savior appeared, 5 he rescued
us, not on the basis of any righteous acts we had performed, but
because of his own compassion, by means of the bath of new birth
and the renewing work of the Holy Spirit,[b] 6 whom he poured out on
us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, 7 so that, made righteous
by his grace, we might become heirs with the hope of eternal life. 8
Here is a trustworthy saying.[c] On these matters I want you to speak
with confidence, so that those who have put their trust in God may
be intent on devoting themselves to good works.[d] These things are
excellent and of benefit to everyone. 9 But avoid foolish controversies
and genealogies, dissensions and quarrels about the law, for they are
unprofitable and futile. 10 Give one warning, then a second, to anyone
who stirs up division,[e] and after that have no more to do with him;
11 you may be sure that a man like that has turned aside and goes on
sinning, condemned by his own verdict.
12 As soon as I send Artemas to you, or Tychicus,[f] make every effort to
join me at Nicopolis,[g] since that is where I have resolved to pass the
winter. 13 Do all you can to help Zenas the lawyer and Apollos on their
way, and see that they lack nothing.[h] 14 Our people must also learn to
commit themselves to doing good, so as to supply urgent needs and
not be unproductive.
15 All who are with me send you greetings. Greet those who love us
in the faith. Grace be with you all.[i]

Notes

- a (3:4) Love for humankind: Greek *philanthrōpia*, from which English "philanthropy" comes.
- b (3:5) Rebirth: Greek *palingenesia*, "new beginning," "regeneration." *Washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit*: or "the washing of rebirth, and renewal by the Holy Spirit."
- c (3:8) Here is a trustworthy saying: literally "faithful is the word"; compare 1 Tim 1:15. It probably refers to verses 4–7.
- d (3:8) Devoting themselves to good works: or "taking the lead in honest occupations"; so also in verse 14.

- e (3:10) Stirs up division: Greek *hairetikos*, “factious,” from which English “heretic” comes.
- f (3:12) *Artemas*: Greek, short for *Artemidoros*, “gift of Artemis.” *Tychicus*: Greek, “fortunate”; compare 2 Tim 4:12.
- g (3:12) Nicopolis: Greek, “city of victory”; probably the city of that name in Epirus, on the western coast of Greece.
- h (3:13) *Zenas*: Greek, short for *Zenodoros*, “gift of Zeus.” *Lawyer*: either an expert in the Jewish law or a Roman jurist. *Apollos*: Greek, short for *Apollonios*, “belonging to Apollo”; compare Acts 18:24; 1 Cor 3:6.
- i (3:15) With you all: the “you” is plural. Later manuscripts add “Amen.”

Philemon

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Paul,[a] a prisoner of Christ Jesus, and Timothy[b] our brother, to
Philemon,[c] our dear friend and fellow worker, 2 and to Apphia[d] our
sister, and to Archippus[e] our fellow soldier, and to the church that
meets in your house. 3 Grace to you and peace from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.
4 I always give thanks to my God when I remember you in my prayers,
5 because I keep hearing about your love and the faithfulness you
show toward the Lord Jesus and all God's holy people.[f] 6 My prayer
is that the sharing that springs from your faith may prove active and
powerful, through a full knowledge of all the good that is ours in
Christ.[g] 7 For I have had much joy and encouragement from your love,
because the hearts[h] of the holy people have been refreshed through
you, brother.
8 For this reason, though in Christ I have every right to be bold and to
order you to do what is fitting, 9 yet for love's sake I prefer to make a
request. Being who I am, Paul, an old man,[i] and at present a prisoner
of Christ Jesus as well, 10 appeal to you for my child, whom I fathered
in my chains: Onesimus.[j] 11 Once he was useless to you, but now he
is truly useful,[k] both to you and to me. 12 I am sending him back to
you, and in sending him I am sending my very heart. 13 I wanted to
keep him here with me, so that he might serve me on your behalf
while I am in chains for the good news.[l] 14 But I chose to do nothing
without your agreement, so that your goodness would not come from
compulsion but from your own free will. 15 Maybe this is why he was
away from you for a time,[m] so that you might receive him back for
good, 16 no longer merely as a slave but as something better than a
slave, a beloved brother. He is especially precious to me, and still more
to you, both as a person[n] and in the Lord. 17 So if you count me as

your partner, welcome him as you would welcome me. 18 And if he
has done you any wrong, or is in debt to you at all, put it down to me.
19 I, Paul, am writing this with my own hand: I will repay it. I need not
mention to you that you owe me your very self. 20 Yes, brother, let me
have some benefit[o] from you in the Lord. Refresh my heart in Christ.
21 I am writing to you confident of your obedience, knowing that you
will do even more than I say. 22 And one more thing: prepare a guest
room for me, because I hope that through your prayers I will be given
back to you.[p]
23 Epaphras,[q] my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, sends you greetings,
24 and so do Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke, my fellow workers.[r]
25 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.[s]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, "small." Paul also had the Jewish name *Saul* (Acts 13:9), after the first king of Israel ("asked for").
- b (1:1) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, "one who honors God." He was Paul's long-time coworker (Acts 16:1–3).
- c (1:1) *Philemon*: Greek, "affectionate" or "one who loves." He was evidently a believer of some means in Colossae (compare Col 4:9, 17), in whose house the church met.
- d (1:2) *Apphia*: a name known from inscriptions in Phrygia; its meaning is uncertain. She is often thought to be Philemon's wife, but the letter does not say so.
- e (1:2) *Archippus*: Greek, "master of horses" (compare Col 4:17).
- f (1:5) God's holy people: Greek *hagioi*, "holy ones," traditionally "saints," the believers as set apart for God; also in verse 7.
- g (1:6) The Greek of this verse is compressed and has been understood in several ways. *Fellowship* (*koinōnia*) may mean the sharing that comes from faith, or Philemon's generous sharing with others. *Ours*: literally "in us"; some manuscripts read "in you." *In Christ*: literally "into Christ," which may mean "for the sake of Christ," "bringing us closer to Christ," or "to the glory of Christ."
- h (1:7) Hearts: Greek *splanchna*, literally "inward parts," the seat of the affections; also in verses 12 and 20.
- i (1:9) An old man: Greek *presbytēs*. Some scholars suggest emending it to *presbeutēs*, "ambassador" (compare Eph 6:20), but no manuscript is known to read this, and the text is kept.
- j (1:10) *Onesimus*: Greek, "useful" or "profitable," a name common among slaves. Paul plays on its meaning in verse 11 and again in verse 20. *Fathered*: that is, Paul led him to faith while in prison.

- k (1:11) Useless ... useful: Greek *achrēstos* ... *euchrēstos*, a play on the name *Onesimus*. The words may also echo *Christos*, which was pronounced much like *chrēstos*, "useful" or "kind."
- l (1:13) Good news: Greek *euangelion*, traditionally "gospel."
- m (1:15) A short time: literally "for an hour," an idiom for a brief period, not a clock time.
- n (1:16) As a man: literally "in the flesh," that is, in ordinary human relationships, including his place in Philemon's household.
- o (1:20) Have some benefit: Greek *onaimēn*, from the same root as *Onesimus*, another play on the name.
- p (1:22) Your prayers ... to you: here "you" is plural, addressing the whole church, as also in verses 3 and 25.
- q (1:23) *Epaphras*: a shortened form of *Epaphroditus*, "charming" or "belonging to Aphrodite." He was from Colossae and founded the church there (Col 1:7; 4:12). He is probably a different person from the Epaphroditus of Philippians.
- r (1:24) *Mark*: Latin *Marcus*, probably "of Mars"; he is John Mark (Acts 12:12; Col 4:10). *Aristarchus*: Greek, "best ruler," from Thessalonica (Acts 19:29; 27:2). *Demas*: probably short for *Demetrius*, "belonging to Demeter" (compare 2 Tim 4:10). *Luke*: Greek *Loukas*, a Latin name probably meaning "from Lucania" (Col 4:14).
- s (1:25) Some later manuscripts add "Amen."

Hebrews

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 In many portions and in many ways God spoke long ago to our
ancestors through the prophets,[a] 2 but in these final days he has
addressed us through a Son, whom he designated heir of everything
and through whom he also created the universe.[b] 3 He is the radiance
of God's glory and the exact imprint of his very being, and he bears
up all things by his mighty word. After he had made purification for
sins, he took his seat at the right hand of the Majesty on high,[c] 4 So he
has come to rank as far above the angels as the name he has received
as his inheritance surpasses theirs.
5 To which of the angels, then, did God ever say,
"My Son you are;
this day I have fathered you"?[d]
Or again,
"I myself will be Father to him,
and he for his part will be Son to me"?[e]
6 And when, again, he leads the firstborn into the inhabited world, he
declares,
"All the angels of God must bow down before him."[f]
7 Of the angels he says,
"He makes his angels winds,
and his ministers a flame of fire."[g]
8 But of the Son he says,
"Your throne, O God, is forever and ever,
and the scepter of uprightness is the scepter of his kingdom.[h]
9 You have loved justice and hated lawlessness;
therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of gladness beyond your companions."

10 And,
"You, Lord, set the earth's foundations at the start,
and the skies are made by your hands.[i]
11 These will come to ruin, but you continue;
like clothing, every one of them will grow old.
12 You will fold them up like a robe,
and like clothing they will be replaced.
But you remain the same,
and your years will never run out."[j]
13 To which of the angels has he at any time said,
"Take your seat at my right hand
while I lay your foes beneath your feet as a footstool"?[k]
14 Are they not all spirits in holy service, sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation?[l]

Notes

- a (1:1) Our ancestors: literally "the fathers."
- b (1:2) In these last days: literally "at the end of these days." *The ages*: or "the universe," "the worlds."
- c (1:3) Radiance: or "reflection." *Exact imprint*: Greek *charaktēr*, the mark stamped on a coin or seal. *Purification for sins*: later manuscripts read "purification for our sins by himself." *Took his seat … at the right hand*: echoing Ps 110:1.
- d (1:5) Ps 2:7. *I have become your Father*: literally "I have begotten you."
- e (1:5) 2 Sam 7:14; 1 Chr 17:13.
- f (1:6) Deut 32:43 in the Greek Old Testament (not in the standard Hebrew text, but compare a Hebrew copy among the Dead Sea Scrolls); compare Ps 97:7. *Again, when he brings*: or "when he again brings."
- g (1:7) Ps 104:4 in the Greek Old Testament. *Winds*: or "spirits"; the same Greek word means both.
- h (1:8) Ps 45:6–7. *Your throne, O God, is*: or "God is your throne." *Forever and ever*: Westcott and Hort bracket "and ever." *His kingdom*: so the Westcott–Hort text, following P46, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus as reported; most manuscripts read "your kingdom."
- i (1:10) Ps 102:25–27 in the Greek Old Testament. *Lord*: the Greek Old Testament adds this word; in the Hebrew psalm the one addressed is Yahweh (verses 12, 19).
- j (1:12) Like a garment: these words are not in the psalm; P46, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and Vaticanus as reported include them here, while later manuscripts omit them.
- k (1:13) Ps 110:1.
- l (1:14) Spirits in holy service: literally "ministering spirits."

Chapter 2

1 For this reason it is all the more necessary for us to hold on to the
things we have heard, or we may be carried off course. 2 For if the
message spoken through angels proved valid, and every violation and
disobedience received its just penalty,[a] 3 how can we avoid punish-
ment if we ignore such a great salvation? The Lord first announced
it, and those who listened to him confirmed it for us, 4 while God
corroborated it with signs, wonders, and a variety of miracles, and by
distributing gifts of the Holy Spirit according to his will.
5 It was not to angels, after all, that he made subject the coming world
we are speaking about.
6 Somewhere a witness declares,

"What is a human being, that you give him a thought,
or a mortal, that you look after him?[b]
7 For a brief time you ranked him beneath the angels;
you wreathed him with glory and honor;[c]
8 all things you have placed beneath his feet."

In subjecting all things to him, he has left nothing outside his rule.
Yet at present we do not see all things made subject to him.
9 What we do see is Jesus, made for a short time lower than the angels,
and now, on account of the death he suffered, wearing a crown of
glory and honor, so that by God's grace he might taste death on behalf
of every one.[d]
10 It was right that God, the one for whose sake and by whose agency
everything exists, should bring the founder of their salvation to
completion through sufferings, as he leads many sons into glory.[e]
11 For the one who makes holy and those who are made holy all have
one origin. That is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers,[f]
12 when he says,

"I will make your name known to my brothers;
among the gathered congregation I will sing hymns to you."[g]
13 And again,
"I will put my trust in him."[h]

And again,

"Here I am, and the children God has given me."[i]

14 Because the children share flesh and blood, he likewise shared in
these, so that by dying he might destroy the one who has the power
of death, namely the devil,[j] 15 and set free all those who through fear
of death were held in slavery all their lives. 16 For surely it is not
angels he takes hold of to help, but he takes hold of the descendants of
Abraham.[k] 17 So it was necessary for him to become like his brothers
in all things, in order to be a high priest merciful and faithful in what
concerns God, making atonement for the people's sins.[l] 18 Because he
himself suffered when he was tested, he is able to help those who are
being tested.[m]

Notes

- a (2:2) The message spoken through angels: Jewish tradition held that angels took part in the giving of the law at Sinai; compare Deut 33:2 in the Greek Old Testament; Acts 7:53; Gal 3:19.
- b (2:6) Ps 8:4–6 in the Greek Old Testament. *Man … son of man*: a human being, humankind. In verses 8–9 the writer applies the psalm to Jesus.
- c (2:7) For a little while: or "a little." The Hebrew of Ps 8:5 reads "a little lower than God" (or "than divine beings"). *Honor*: later manuscripts add "and set him over the works of your hands"; Westcott and Hort bracket these words.
- d (2:9) *Jesus*: the Greek form of Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), "Yahweh saves." *By the grace of God*: so nearly all manuscripts. A few manuscripts, and some writers known to Origen in the 3rd century, read *chōris theou*, "apart from God," instead of *chariti theou*, "by the grace of God." The rarer reading is defended by some scholars as the harder one; most editors follow the reading in the text.
- e (2:10) Sons: including daughters; the Greek uses the masculine plural for a mixed group. *Founder*: Greek *archēgos*, "leader," "pioneer," "trailblazer." *Bring … to completion*: or "make perfect."
- f (2:11) One origin: literally "are all from one," that is, from one Father, or from one family. *Brothers*: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters when used of a group; so throughout.
- g (2:12) Ps 22:22. *Assembly*: Greek *ekklēsia*, the word usually rendered "church."
- h (2:13) Isa 8:17 in the Greek Old Testament; compare 2 Sam 22:3.
- i (2:13) Isa 8:18.
- j (2:14) The devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer."
- k (2:16) Takes hold of: or "gives help to." *Descendants*: literally "seed." *Abraham*: Hebrew, explained in Gen 17:5 as "father of a multitude."
- l (2:17) Making atonement for: or "making propitiation for," "wipe away."

• m (2:18) Tested: or “tempted”; the same Greek word covers both.

Chapter 3

1 So then, holy brothers, who share in a heavenly calling, fix your
thoughts on Jesus, the apostle and high priest of the faith we confess.[a]
2 He has been faithful to the one who appointed him, as Moses too
was faithful in all his house.[b] 3 But Jesus has been counted worthy of
greater glory than Moses, in the way that the one who builds a house
is held in higher honor than the house. 4 Every house has its builder,
and the one who built all things is God. 5 Moses indeed was faithful
in all God’s house, as an attendant, bearing witness to the things that
were going to be spoken,[c] 6 but Christ is faithful as a Son set over
God’s house; and that house is ourselves, provided we keep firm hold
of our boldness and of the hope that is our boast.[d]
7 Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says,
“Today, if you hear his voice,
8 do not make your hearts hard as they did at the Provocation,
at the time of the Testing in the desert,[e]
9 where your ancestors put me to the test by trying me,
though they saw my works for forty years.
10 That is why I was angry with that generation,
and I said, ‘Their hearts always go astray;
they have not known my ways.’
11 So in my wrath I swore an oath:
‘Into my rest they shall not come.’ ”[f]
12 Take care, brothers, that none of you has an evil, unbelieving heart
that turns away from the living God.
13 Rather, keep urging one another on, day by day, for as long as there
is a “today,” so that sin’s deceit may harden none of you.
14 For we have come to share in Christ, provided that we keep the
confidence we had at the start unshaken to the last.[g]
15 In the words of Scripture,
“Today, if you should hear his voice,
do not make your hearts hard as they did at the Provocation.”

16 Who were they who heard and yet rebelled? Was it not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses?
17 And with whom was God angry for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness?[h]
18 To whom did he swear that they would never come into his rest? Was it not to those who refused to obey?
19 And we see that unbelief kept them from coming in.

Notes

- a (3:1) Apostle: Greek *apostolos*, "one sent." *Jesus*: later manuscripts read "Christ Jesus." *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "Anointed One," equivalent to Hebrew *mashiach*, "Messiah."
- b (3:2) *Moses*: Hebrew *Mosheh*, explained in Exod 2:10 as "drawn out"; it may come from an Egyptian word for "son." *In all God's house*: Num 12:7 in the Greek Old Testament; literally "in all his house." Westcott and Hort bracket "all"; P13, P46 and Vaticanus as reported omit it.
- c (3:5) Attendant: Greek *therapōn*, an attendant, from Num 12:7.
- d (3:6) *Hope that is our boast*: later manuscripts add "firm to the end"; Westcott and Hort bracket these words, which P13, P46 and Vaticanus as reported omit (compare verse 14).
- e (3:8) Ps 95:7–11 in the Greek Old Testament. *The rebellion … testing*: in Hebrew these are the place names *Meribah*, "quarreling," and *Massah*, "testing" (Exod 17:7; Num 20:13).
- f (3:11) They shall not come: literally "if they shall enter," a Hebrew form of oath meaning "they shall not enter."
- g (3:14) Come to share in Christ: or "become partners of Christ." *Confidence*: Greek *hypostasis*, "assurance," "resolve"; compare 1:3; 11:1.
- h (3:17) Whose bodies fell: compare Num 14:29, 32.

Chapter 4

1 Since, then, the promise of entering his rest still stands, let us be wary that none of you should seem to have fallen short of it.
2 For good news has been brought to us as well as to them. Yet the word they heard was of no benefit to them, because they were not joined in faith with those who truly listened.[a]
3 For we who trust do enter that rest, as he said,

"So I vowed in my anger,
'They will never come into my rest,' "
even though his work was done from the creation of the world.[b]

4 For in one place he speaks of the seventh day like this: “God rested
from all his works on the seventh day.”[c]
5 And again in this passage he says, “They shall never enter my rest.”
6 It still remains, then, that some are to come into it, and since those to
whom the good news came first did not come in, because they would
not obey,
7 God fixes another day, a “today,” speaking through David a long time
later in the words already cited,

“Today, if you should hear his voice,
do not make your hearts hard.”[d]

8 Had Joshua given them rest, God would not afterward have spoken
of a further day.[e]
9 So then, a sabbath rest remains for the people of God;[f]
10 for anyone who has come into God’s rest has ceased from his labors,
just as God ceased from his own.
11 So let us be earnest to come into that rest, so that none of us falls
through the same kind of disobedience they showed.
12 For God’s word is alive and powerful, cutting more sharply than
any double-edged sword, slicing through to the place where soul and
spirit, joints and marrow meet, and able to assess the heart’s thoughts
and motives. 13 No creature is hidden from his sight, but all things
are bare and laid open to the eyes of the one to whom we must give
account.[g]
14 Since, then, we have a great high priest who has passed through the
heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast the faith we confess. 15
Ours is not a high priest who cannot feel for us in our frailties; he has
been put to the test in all things just as we are, yet without sinning.
16 Let us then approach the throne of grace boldly, to receive mercy
and discover grace that helps when we need it.

Notes

- a (4:2) Because they were not united in faith with those who listened: so the Westcott–Hort text, with most early manuscripts as reported. Some manuscripts read “because it was not combined with faith in those who heard it.”
- b (4:3) Ps 95:11.
- c (4:4) Gen 2:2.

- d (4:7) *David*: Hebrew, probably “beloved.” The Greek Old Testament gives Psalm 95 a heading naming David.
- e (4:8) *Joshua*: Hebrew *Yehoshua*, “Yahweh saves”; the Greek name is *Iēsous*, the same as “Jesus.”
- f (4:9) Sabbath rest: Greek *sabbatismos*, “sabbath-keeping”; *sabbath* is Hebrew for “ceasing,” “rest.”
- g (4:13) Laid open: literally “with the neck bent back,” exposed. *To whom we must give account*: or “with whom we have to do.”

Chapter 5

1 Every high priest is chosen from among men and appointed to act
on their behalf in matters relating to God, to offer gifts and sacrifices
for sins. 2 He is able to deal gently with the ignorant and the wayward,
since he himself is beset by weakness. 3 and for that reason he has
to bring an offering for sins on his own account as well as on behalf
of the people. 4 And no one takes this honor on himself; he must be
called by God, just as Aaron was.[a]
5 So also Christ did not glorify himself by becoming a high priest; it
was given him by the one who said to him,

“You are my Son;
today I have become your Father.”[b]

6 As he also says in another place,

“You are a priest forever,
in the order of Melchizedek.”[c]

7 During his life in the flesh he offered prayers and earnest requests,
with a loud outcry and with tears, to the one who had power to rescue
him from death, and he was heard because of his devotion.[d]
8 Son though he was, he learned obedience from the things he
suffered.[e]
9 And once made complete, he became for all who obey him the cause
of salvation that lasts forever,
10 since God designated him a high priest in the order of Melchizedek.
11 On this subject we have a great deal to say, and it is difficult to
make clear, because you have grown dull of hearing. 12 By now you
should be teaching others, yet you need someone to teach you once
more the basic rudiments of the sayings of God. You have come to

need milk rather than solid food.[f] 13 For everyone who lives on milk is
unacquainted with the message of righteousness, being still an infant.
14 But solid food belongs to the mature, to those whose faculties have
been trained by practice to tell good from evil.

Notes

- a (5:4) *Aaron*: Hebrew, of uncertain meaning; Moses' brother and the first high priest (Exod 28:1).
- b (5:5) Ps 2:7.
- c (5:6) Ps 110:4. *Melchizedek*: Hebrew, "my king is righteousness" or "king of righteousness" (7:2); the king and priest of Salem who blessed Abraham (Gen 14:18–20). *In the order of*: or "after the manner of."
- d (5:7) Because of his devotion: or "because of his reverent fear"; others render "and was delivered from his fear."
- e (5:8) He learned … he suffered: Greek *emathen … epathen*, a play on words.
- f (5:12) Basic rudiments: or "first principles," literally "the elements of the beginning."

Chapter 6

1 So let us leave behind the elementary teaching about Christ and
press on to maturity, not laying again a foundation of repentance
from dead works and of faith in God,[a] 2 teaching about washings and
the laying on of hands, about the raising of the dead and the judgment
that lasts forever.[b] 3 And this we will do, if God permits. 4 There is
no way, when people have once received the light, have tasted the
gift from heaven, have come to share in the Holy Spirit, 5 who have
experienced how good God's word is, and the powers of the coming
age, 6 and then have fallen away, to bring them back to repentance
again; for they are crucifying the Son of God afresh to their own ruin,
and making a public mockery of him.[c] 7 Ground that soaks up the rain
falling on it time after time, and brings forth plants of use to those
for whom it is worked, has a share in God's blessing. 8 But land that
yields thorns and thistles is worthless and close to a curse, and in the
end it is burned.[d]

9 Even though we speak this way, dear friends, we are confident of
better things in your case, things that go with salvation. 10 For God is
not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you showed for
his name in serving the saints, as you still serve them.[e] 11 And we long

for each one of you to show the same eagerness for the full assurance
of hope until the end, 12 so that you may not become sluggish, but
imitate those who through faith and patience inherit the promises.
13 When God gave his promise to Abraham, he swore by himself,
because there was no one greater for him to swear by, 14 saying,
"Surely I will bless you and multiply you."[f] 15 And so Abraham, having
waited with patience, received what was promised. 16 People swear
by someone greater than themselves, and for them an oath serves as
confirmation and puts an end to every dispute. 17 In the same way,
God, wanting to show the heirs of the promise even more plainly
that his purpose could not change, guaranteed it with an oath, 18 so
that through two things that cannot change, in which God cannot
possibly lie, we who have taken refuge might be strongly encouraged
to lay hold of the hope that lies before us. 19 This hope we hold as
the soul's anchor, firm and secure, and it goes in to the inner place
beyond the curtain,[g] 20 where Jesus has entered for us as a forerunner,
having become a high priest forever in the order of Melchizedek.

Notes

- a (6:1) The elementary teaching about Christ: literally "the word of the beginning of the Christ." *Maturity*: or "perfection," "completion."
- b (6:2) Teaching about washings: so the Westcott–Hort text, following Vaticanus as reported ("a foundation … teaching"); most manuscripts read "of teaching about washings." *Washings*: Greek *baptismoi*, "baptisms," "ritual washings."
- c (6:6) For they are crucifying: or "while they are crucifying." *Afresh*: or "for themselves"; the Greek *anastaurountas* can mean either.
- d (6:8) Thorns and thistles: compare Gen 3:17–18.
- e (6:10) Saints: literally "holy ones," that is, God's people.
- f (6:14) Gen 22:17. *Surely I will bless you and multiply you*: literally "blessing I will bless you and multiplying I will multiply you."
- g (6:19) The inner place beyond the curtain: the inmost room of the sanctuary, the Most Holy Place (Lev 16:2, 12).

Chapter 7

1 For this Melchizedek, king of Salem and priest of God Most High,
went out to meet Abraham when he came back from the slaughter
of the kings, and he blessed him;[a] 2 and Abraham gave him a tenth of
everything. His name means first "king of righteousness," and then

he is also king of Salem, that is, "king of peace." [3] He is without father,
without mother, without genealogy, having neither beginning of days
nor end of life; but, made like the Son of God, he remains a priest for
all time.[b]
[4] Notice how great this man was, to whom the patriarch Abraham
gave one tenth of the plunder. [5] The descendants of Levi who receive
the priesthood are ordered by the law to collect a tenth from the
people, from their own relatives, although they too are Abraham's
descendants.[c] [6] But this man, whose ancestry is not traced from them,
took tithes from Abraham and gave a blessing to the man who held
the promises. [7] Beyond any dispute, the lesser is blessed by the greater.
[8] In the first case, tenths are collected by mortals; in the second, by
someone who is declared to be alive. [9] One might even say that Levi,
who receives tithes, paid tithes through Abraham, [10] for he was still
in the body of his ancestor when Melchizedek met him.[d]
[11] If, then, the Levitical priesthood could have brought about perfection, for it was in connection with it that the people were given the
law, why was there still need for a different priest to arise in the line
of Melchizedek, and not one designated in the line of Aaron?
[12] For when the priesthood is changed, a change of law necessarily
follows as well.
[13] The one these things are spoken of belonged to another tribe, from
which no one has ever served at the altar.
[14] For it is evident that our Lord arose from Judah, and Moses said
nothing about priests in connection with that tribe.[e]
[15] And this becomes still more evident when another priest arises who
resembles Melchizedek,
[16] one who has become priest, not by virtue of a rule about bodily
descent, but by virtue of the power of a life that cannot be destroyed.[f]
[17] For the testimony is,

"A priest you are forever,
in the line of Melchizedek."

[18] On the one side, a previous commandment is canceled because it
was feeble and ineffective,

19 for the law brought nothing to completion. In its place a better hope
is brought in, and by it we come near to God.
20 And it did not happen without an oath. Others became priests
without an oath,
21 but this one became priest on oath, when God declared to him,
"The Lord has taken an oath
and will not go back on it:
'A priest you are forever.' "[g]
22 To that same degree Jesus has become the guarantee of a better
covenant.
23 Furthermore, the former priests were many in number, because
death prevented them from continuing in office;
24 He, however, because he lives on forever, holds a priesthood that
does not pass to another.
25 That is why he can save for all time those who come to God by him;
he is always alive to plead on their behalf.[h]
26 It was fitting that we should have such a high priest: holy, innocent,
undefiled, separated from sinners, and exalted above the heavens. 27
He has no need, as those high priests do, to offer sacrifices day after
day, first for his own sins and then for those of the people; for he did
this once for all when he offered up himself. 28 For the law appoints
as high priests men who are subject to weakness, but the word of the
oath, which came after the law, appoints a Son who has been made
perfect forever.

Notes

- a (7:1) *Salem*: Hebrew, "peace"; usually identified with Jerusalem (Ps 76:2). *God Most High*: Hebrew *El Elyon*. See Gen 14:17–20.
- b (7:3) Without father … genealogy: Genesis records no parents, ancestry, birth or death for him.
- c (7:5) *Levi*: Hebrew, explained in Gen 29:34 as "attached." *Descended from*: literally "have come out of the loins of."
- d (7:10) In the body of his ancestor: literally "in the loins of his father."
- e (7:14) *Judah*: Hebrew, explained in Gen 29:35 as "praise." *Arose*: the Greek verb is used of the rising of a star or the springing up of a plant; compare Isa 11:1; Jer 23:5.
- f (7:16) A rule about bodily descent: literally "a law of a fleshly commandment."

- g (7:21) Ps 110:4. *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*. *Forever*: later manuscripts add “in the order of Melchizedek.”
- h (7:25) For all time: or “completely.”

Chapter 8

1 The chief point of what we are saying is this: we have a high priest
of this kind, who sat down at the right hand of the throne of the
Majesty in heaven, 2 a minister in the sanctuary and in the true tent,
which the Lord set up, not any human being.[a] 3 For every high priest
is appointed to offer gifts and sacrifices, so it is necessary for this one
too to have something to offer. 4 Now if he were on earth, he would
not be a priest at all, since there are already priests who offer the
gifts according to the law. 5 They minister in a sketch and shadow of
what is in heaven, just as Moses was cautioned when he was about to
build the tent: “Be sure to make everything after the model you were
shown on the mountain.”[b] 6 As it is, however, the ministry Christ has
received is far more excellent, to the same degree that the covenant
of which he is mediator is better, resting as it does on better promises.
7 If that first covenant had been flawless, a second would never have
been sought.

8 For he faults them when he says,
“Behold, days are coming, declares the Lord,
when I will make a new covenant
with Israel’s house and Judah’s house.[c]
9 It will not be like the covenant that I made with their ancestors
on the day when I took them by the hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt;
because they did not continue in my covenant,
I too disregarded them, says the Lord.[d]
10 For this is the covenant I will make with the house of Israel
when those days are over, says the Lord:
I will place my laws in their understanding,
and inscribe them upon their hearts;
I will be God to them,
and they will be a people to me.

11 No longer will each one teach his fellow townsman,
or each one his brother, saying, 'Know the Lord.'
For all of them will know me,
from the smallest to the greatest.[e]
12 For I will be merciful toward their wrongdoings,
and I will remember their sins no more."[f]
13 When he says "new," he has made the first covenant old; and what is growing old and aging will soon disappear.

Notes

- a (8:2) The sanctuary: literally "the holy things" or "the holy places." *Tent*: or "tabernacle," the portable sanctuary of Israel in the wilderness; compare Num 24:6 in the Greek Old Testament.
- b (8:5) Exod 25:40.
- c (8:8) Jer 31:31–34 (38:31–34 in the Greek Old Testament). *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*; so also in verses 9–10. *Israel*: Hebrew, explained in Gen 32:28 as "he struggles with God."
- d (8:9) I too disregarded them: so the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew reads "though I was a husband to them."
- e (8:11) Know the Lord: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*.
- f (8:12) Their sins: later manuscripts add "and their lawless deeds," as in 10:17.

Chapter 9

1 The first covenant, for its part, had rules for worship and a sanctuary belonging to this world.[a] 2 A tent was set up, the outer section, which held the lampstand, the table, and the loaves set out before God; this is called the Holy Place.[b] 3 Behind the second curtain was the room called the Most Holy Place,[c] 4 It contained the golden incense altar and the covenant chest, plated all over with gold. Inside the chest were the golden jar of manna, Aaron's rod that had budded, and the stone tablets of the covenant.[d] 5 and over it the cherubim of the Glory cast their shadow over the mercy seat. We cannot speak about these things one by one at present.[e]

6 With these things arranged in this way, the priests go regularly into the first room in performing their duties, 7 Into the second room, however, the high priest alone goes, only once a year, and always with blood, which he brings as an offering for himself and for the sins of the people done in ignorance.[f] 8 The Holy Spirit is making it plain

by this that the way into the sanctuary has not yet been opened as
long as the first tent still has its standing. 9 This is a figure pointing to
the present time. Under it gifts and sacrifices are brought that have
no power to make the worshiper perfect in conscience,[g] 10 dealing
only with foods and drinks and different kinds of washing. These
are outward rules for the body, in force until the time comes to set
things straight.
11 But when Christ appeared as a high priest of the good things that
have now come, then through the greater and more perfect tent,
not made with hands, that is, not of this creation,[h] 12 he entered the
sanctuary once and for all, not with the blood of goats and calves
but with his own blood, and secured an everlasting redemption. 13 For
if the blood of goats and bulls and the sprinkled ashes of a heifer
sanctify those who are defiled, so that their flesh is made clean,[i] 14 how
much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit
presented himself to God without fault, cleanse our consciences of
dead works so that we may serve the living God![j]
15 For this reason he mediates a new covenant, so that the called may
receive the promised everlasting inheritance, now that a death has
occurred to redeem them from the offenses committed under the first
covenant. 16 In the case of a will, it is necessary to establish that the
one who made it has died.[k] 17 A will is valid only once someone has
died; it has no force as long as the one who made it is still living. 18
That is why not even the first covenant was put into effect without
blood. 19 For when every command of the law had been spoken by
Moses to all the people, he took the blood of calves and goats, with
water and scarlet wool and hyssop, and sprinkled both the book itself
and all the people,[l] 20 saying, "This is the blood of the covenant that
God has commanded for you."[m] 21 Likewise he sprinkled blood on the
tent and on every vessel used in the ministry. 22 In fact, under the
law nearly everything is made clean with blood, and apart from the
pouring out of blood there is no forgiveness.
23 It was necessary, then, for the copies of the things in heaven to be
cleansed by such means, but the heavenly things themselves needed
better sacrifices than these. 24 For Christ did not enter a sanctuary

built by human hands, a mere image of the true one, but heaven itself, now to stand before God for our sake. 25 Nor was it to offer himself many times over, as the high priest goes into the holy place each year with blood that is not his own; 26 if that were so, he would have needed to suffer many times since the world was founded. Instead he has been revealed once, at the end of the ages, to do away with sin by sacrificing himself. 27 And just as it is appointed for human beings to die once, and after that comes judgment, 28 so also Christ, having been offered once to bear the sins of many, will appear a second time, not to deal with sin, but to bring salvation to those who are eagerly waiting for him.[n]

Notes

- a (9:1) For its part: Westcott and Hort bracket the word “also” (or “even”) here. *A sanctuary belonging to this world*: or “an earthly sanctuary.”
- b (9:2) The bread of the presence: literally “the setting out of the loaves” (Exod 25:30; Lev 24:5–9).
- c (9:3) The Most Holy Place: literally “the holy of holies.”
- d (9:4) Altar of incense: or “censer”; the Greek *thymiatērion* can mean either. In Exodus the incense altar stood in front of the curtain (Exod 30:6). *Manna*: Hebrew, explained in Exod 16:15, 31 from the question “What is it?” See Exod 16:33; Num 17:8–10; Deut 10:1–5.
- e (9:5) Cherubim: Hebrew plural of *cherub*, winged heavenly beings. *Mercy seat*: Greek *hilastērion*, the gold lid of the ark, “place of atonement” (Exod 25:17–22).
- f (9:7) Once a year: on the Day of Atonement (Lev 16), in the seventh month (September–October), on its tenth day.
- g (9:9) Figure: Greek *parabolē*, “parable,” “figure.”
- h (9:11) That have now come: so the Westcott–Hort text, with P46 and Vaticanus as reported; many manuscripts read “that are to come.”
- i (9:13) Ashes of a heifer: see Num 19:1–10, 17–19.
- j (9:14) Our conscience: so the Westcott–Hort text; many manuscripts read “your conscience.” *The eternal Spirit*: or “an eternal spirit.”
- k (9:16) Will: the Greek *diathēkē* means both “covenant” and “will” (“testament”), and the writer plays on both senses in verses 15–18.
- l (9:19) Hyssop: a small aromatic plant used for sprinkling. Compare Exod 24:3–8. *Calves and goats*: some manuscripts read only “calves.”
- m (9:20) Exod 24:8.
- n (9:28) To bear the sins of many: echoing Isa 53:12.

Chapter 10

1 The law holds only a shadow of the good things that were to come,
not the very form of those realities. So by the same sacrifices, offered
without end year by year, it can never make perfect those who come
forward to worship.[a] 2 If they could, would the offering of them not
have come to an end, since those who worship, once made clean,
would have no further awareness of sins? 3 Instead, these sacrifices
bring sins to mind again every year, 4 since the blood of bulls and
goats cannot possibly take sins away.
5 That is why, as he comes into the world, Christ says,
"Sacrifice and offering you did not want,
but a body you have made ready for me;[b]
6 in offerings burned whole and in offerings for sin
you found no pleasure.
7 Then I said, 'See, I have come;
in the scroll of the book it is written about me,
to do your will, God.' "
8 First he says, "Sacrifices and offerings, whole burnt offerings and sin
offerings you did not want and took no pleasure in," though these are
offered according to the law.
9 Then he adds, "Here I am; I have come to do your will." He sets aside
the first in order to establish the second.
10 By that will we have been made holy, through the sacrifice of Jesus
Christ's body, offered one time for all.
11 Every priest, moreover, stands daily performing his ministry, pre-
senting over and over the identical sacrifices, which are never able to
remove sins.[c]
12 But this one, having offered for all time a single sacrifice for sins,
sat down at God's right hand,[d]
13 and from then on he waits until his enemies are made a footstool
for his feet.[e]
14 For by a single offering he has made perfect for all time those who
are being made holy.
15 And the Holy Spirit testifies to us as well. For after he has said,

16 “This is the covenant I will make with them
when those days are over, says the Lord:
I will place my laws on their hearts,
and inscribe them upon their minds,”[f]
17 he goes on,
“Their sins and their lawless acts
I will call to mind no more.”
18 Where these have been forgiven, there is no longer any offering for sin.
19 So then, brothers, since by Jesus’ blood we have boldness to go into the holy place, 20 by a way newly made and living, which he has opened up for us through the curtain, which is his flesh, 21 and since we have a great priest over the house of God, 22 let us come near with a true heart, in the full assurance that faith gives, our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.
23 Let us keep hold of the hope we confess without wavering, for the one who gave the promise can be trusted. 24 And let us take thought for one another, how to stir each other up to love and good works, 25 not giving up meeting together, as is the custom of some, but urging each other on, and doing so the more as you see the Day drawing near.[g]
26 If we keep on sinning willfully once we have come to know the truth, no sacrifice for sins remains any longer, 27 but only a terrifying expectation of judgment, and a raging fire that will consume the adversaries.[h] 28 Whoever rejected the law of Moses was put to death without pity, when two or three witnesses gave evidence.[i] 29 Imagine how much worse a punishment is deserved by someone who has trampled on the Son of God, treated as common the covenant blood that made him holy, and insulted the Spirit of grace.[j] 30 We know who it is that said, “Retribution belongs to me; I will pay back,” and again, “The Lord will judge his people.”[k] 31 It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God.
32 Remember the earlier days, when after being enlightened you endured a great struggle of suffering.
33 At times you were publicly exposed to insults and afflictions; at other times you stood alongside those who were treated in that way.

34 For you shared the sufferings of the prisoners, and you accepted
with joy the seizure of your possessions, knowing that you yourselves
had a better possession, and a lasting one.[l]
35 So do not throw away your confidence, which carries a great reward.
36 For you need to persevere, so that, having done what God wills, you
may receive the promise.
37 For,

"In just a little while,
the one who is coming will come and will not delay;[m]
38 but my righteous one will live by faith,
and if he shrinks back,
my soul takes no delight in him."[n]

39 We, however, are not people who draw back to their ruin, but people
of faith who hold on to their souls.[o]

Notes

- a (10:1) The very form: literally "the image itself."
- b (10:5) Ps 40:6–8 in the Greek Old Testament. *A body you have made ready for me*: so the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew reads "ears you have dug for me," that is, "you have opened my ears."
- c (10:11) Every priest: some manuscripts read "every high priest."
- d (10:12) For all time: or, taken with what follows, "sat down for all time."
- e (10:13) Ps 110:1.
- f (10:16) Jer 31:33–34. *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*.
- g (10:25) The Day: the day of the Lord's coming and judgment.
- h (10:27) Raging fire: literally "zeal of fire"; compare Isa 26:11.
- i (10:28) Compare Deut 17:6.
- j (10:29) Counted as unclean: or "treated as common." Compare Exod 24:8.
- k (10:30) Deut 32:35–36. *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*. *I will repay*: later manuscripts add "says the Lord."
- l (10:34) The prisoners: so the Westcott–Hort text, with Alexandrinus as reported; later manuscripts read "my chains." *You yourselves had*: later manuscripts add "in heaven."
- m (10:37) In just a little while: literally "a little, how very little," from Isa 26:20. The rest of verses 37–38 is from Hab 2:3–4 in the Greek Old Testament.
- n (10:38) My righteous one: Westcott and Hort bracket "my"; some manuscripts place it after "faith" ("will live by my faith"), and later manuscripts omit it.
- o (10:39) Hold on to their souls: or "gain their lives."

Chapter 11

1 Faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the proof of things
not seen.[a] 2 For it was for this that the elders of long ago were
commended.[b] 3 By faith we grasp that the universe was formed by
God's word, so that the visible was not made from what is seen.[c]
4 By faith Abel presented to God a better sacrifice than Cain did.
Through it he was declared righteous, with God commending his
offerings; and through faith he still speaks, though he died.[d] 5 By faith
Enoch was transferred so that he would not experience death, and "he
could not be found, because God had transferred him." For before the
transfer he was commended as having pleased God.[e] 6 And without
faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever draws near to God
must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him.
7 By faith Noah, when he had been divinely warned about things as
yet unseen, reverently prepared an ark for the rescue of his family.
Through his faith he passed sentence on the world, and he became
heir to the righteousness that accords with faith.[f]
8 By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place
he was going to receive as an inheritance, and he went out without
knowing where he was going. 9 By faith he lived as a foreigner in the
land of promise, as in a land not his own, living in tents with Isaac
and Jacob, fellow heirs of the same promise.[g] 10 He was awaiting the
city with firm foundations, whose architect and maker is God. 11 By
faith Sarah herself, too, received power to conceive offspring, even
beyond the age for it, since she judged the one who had promised to
be faithful.[h] 12 And so from one man, and he as good as dead, there
came descendants as many as the stars of heaven and as countless as
the grains of sand on the seashore.[i]
13 These all died in faith without having received the promises, but
they saw them and greeted them from afar, and they confessed that
they were strangers and exiles on the earth.[j] 14 Those who talk like
this show plainly that they are searching for a homeland. 15 If they had
been thinking of the land they had left behind, they would have had
opportunity to return. 16 But as it is, they long for a better country, a

heavenly one. That is why God is not ashamed to be called their God,
for he has prepared a city for them.
17 By faith Abraham, when tested, offered Isaac as a sacrifice. The
man who had welcomed the promises was offering up his one and
only son,[k] 18 the one of whom it had been said, "Through Isaac your
descendants will be named."[l] 19 He reckoned that God was able even to
raise people from the dead; and figuratively speaking, he did receive
Isaac back from the dead.[m] 20 By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau
with regard to things still to come.[n] 21 By faith Jacob, as he lay dying,
blessed each of Joseph's sons, and leaning on the top of his staff he
worshiped.[o] 22 By faith Joseph, as his end drew near, spoke of the
exodus of the Israelites and gave instructions about his bones.[p]
23 By faith, when Moses was born, his parents kept him hidden three
months, for they saw what a fine child he was, and they did not
fear the decree of the king.[q] 24 By faith Moses, when he had grown
up, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter,[r] 25 choosing
rather to share ill-treatment with the people of God than to enjoy the
passing pleasures of sin. 26 He considered the reproach of the Christ
greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt, for he was looking ahead
to the reward.[s] 27 By faith he left Egypt, not fearing the king's anger, for
he persevered as one who sees him who is invisible. 28 By faith he kept
the Passover and the sprinkling of the blood, so that the destroyer of
the firstborn would not touch them.[t] 29 By faith they passed through
the Red Sea as though on dry land, but when the Egyptians tried to do
the same, they drowned.[u] 30 By faith Jericho's walls collapsed after the
people had marched around them for seven days.[v] 31 By faith Rahab
the prostitute did not die with the disobedient, because she had given
the spies a peaceful welcome.[w]
32 And what more shall I say? For time would fail me to tell of Gideon,
Barak, Samson and Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets,[x]
33 Through faith they overcame kingdoms, carried out justice, gained
what was promised, closed the jaws of lions, 34 put out raging fire,
got away from the sword's edge, found strength in weakness, grew
powerful in battle, routed the armies of foreigners. 35 Women had their
dead given back to them, raised to life. Others were tortured to death,

turning down release so as to gain a better resurrection.[y] [36] Others again had to face jeers and whips, as well as chains and prison. [37] Some were stoned; some were tested; some were sawn apart; some died by the sword. They roamed about clothed in the skins of sheep and goats, in need, in distress, ill-treated,[z] [38] the world did not deserve them; they roamed through deserts, mountains, caves, and holes in the ground.

[39] Yet none of these, though they won approval through their faith, received the promise, [40] because God had in view something better for us, that they should not be brought to perfection without us.

Notes

- a (11:1) Assurance: Greek *hypostasis*, "substance," "firm ground," "title deed"; compare 1:3; 3:14. *Proof*: or "conviction."
- b (11:2) Commended: literally "testified to," that is, by God; so also in verses 4–5, 39.
- c (11:3) The ages: or "the universe"; compare 1:2.
- d (11:4) *Abel*: Hebrew *Hevel*, "breath," "vapor." *Cain*: Hebrew *Qayin*, explained in Gen 4:1 by the word for "acquired." See Gen 4:3–10.
- e (11:5) *Enoch*: Hebrew *Hanokh*, perhaps "dedicated." Gen 5:24 in the Greek Old Testament.
- f (11:7) *Noah*: Hebrew *Noach*, related in Gen 5:29 to a word for "comfort" or "rest." *Took heed*: or "in reverent fear."
- g (11:9) *Isaac*: Hebrew *Yitschaq*, "he laughs" (Gen 17:17–19; 21:6). *Jacob*: Hebrew *Yaʿaqov*, explained in Gen 25:26; 27:36 as "heel-grabber," "supplanter."
- h (11:11) *Sarah*: Hebrew, "princess" (Gen 17:15). *Sarah herself … received power to conceive*: or, as many interpreters read the Greek, "by faith he (Abraham), together with Sarah herself, received power to beget offspring." Some manuscripts add that Sarah was barren; later manuscripts add "gave birth."
- i (11:12) Compare Gen 22:17; 32:12.
- j (11:13) Strangers and exiles: compare Gen 23:4; 1 Chr 29:15; Ps 39:12.
- k (11:17) Only son: Greek *monogenēs*, "one and only." See Gen 22:1–14.
- l (11:18) Gen 21:12. *Descendants*: literally "seed."
- m (11:19) Figuratively speaking: literally "in a parable."
- n (11:20) *Esau*: Hebrew, perhaps "hairy" (Gen 25:25). See Gen 27:27–40.
- o (11:21) *Joseph*: Hebrew *Yosef*, explained in Gen 30:23–24 as "may he add." *Leaning on the top of his staff*: Gen 47:31 in the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew vowels as traditionally read give "at the head of his bed." See also Gen 48:8–20.
- p (11:22) See Gen 50:24–25; Exod 13:19. *The Israelites*: literally "the sons of Israel."

- q (11:23) What a fine child: literally "that the child was beautiful" or "well pleasing"; compare Exod 2:2; Acts 7:20. *Edict*: compare Exod 1:22. Some later manuscripts add here a sentence about Moses killing the Egyptian.
- r (11:24) Pharaoh: Egyptian, "great house," the title of the king of Egypt.
- s (11:26) The reproach of the Christ: or "the reproach of the Anointed One"; compare Ps 89:50–51.
- t (11:28) Passover: Greek *pascha*, from Hebrew *pesach* (Exod 12:11–13, 21–23).
- u (11:29) Red Sea: so the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew has *Yam Suph*, "Sea of Reeds" (Exod 14:21–29).
- v (11:30) *Jericho*: Hebrew, perhaps related to the word for "moon" or "fragrance." See Josh 6:12–21.
- w (11:31) *Rahab*: Hebrew, "broad," "wide." See Josh 2:1–21; 6:22–25.
- x (11:32) *Gideon*: Hebrew, "hewer." *Barak*: Hebrew, "lightning." *Samson*: Hebrew *Shimshon*, from the word for "sun." *Jephthah*: Hebrew *Yiftach*, "he opens." *Samuel*: Hebrew *Shemuel*, explained in 1 Sam 1:20 by the words "asked of God," more probably "name of God."
- y (11:35) Compare 1 Kgs 17:17–24; 2 Kgs 4:18–37. *Tortured*: probably on the rack or drum; compare 2 Macc 6:18–7:42.
- z (11:37) Some were tested: Greek *epeirasthēsan*. Some manuscripts omit it, and some scholars suspect an early copying error for *eprēsthēsan*, "they were burned." *Sawn in two*: a Jewish tradition tells of Isaiah being sawn in two.

Chapter 12

1 With so vast a cloud of witnesses around us, then, let us too throw
off every burden and the sin that entangles so easily, and let us run
with perseverance the course laid out for us,[a] 2 keeping our gaze on
Jesus, who leads the way in faith and brings it to completion. For the
sake of the joy that lay ahead of him he bore the cross, scorning the
shame, and he is seated at the right of God's throne.[b] 3 Consider him
who endured such hostility from sinners against themselves, so that
you do not grow weary and lose heart.[c]

4 You have not yet, in your contest with sin, stood firm to the point
of bloodshed.

5 And you have forgotten the word of encouragement which speaks
to you as to sons:

"My son, do not treat lightly the discipline of the Lord,
nor give up when he rebukes you;[d]

6 because the Lord disciplines those he loves,
and chastises every child he accepts."[e]

7 Endure it as discipline. God is dealing with you as his children. For
what child is not disciplined by a father?
8 If you are without the discipline that all have received, you are not
true sons but illegitimate.
9 Again, we had human fathers who corrected us, and we treated them
with respect. Should we not be far more ready to submit to the Father
of spirits, and so live?[f]
10 Our fathers corrected us for a brief time as they judged fit, but God
does it for our benefit, that we may have a share in his holiness.
11 No discipline, while it lasts, seems a matter for joy; it is painful.
Afterward, though, those who have been schooled by it reap from it
a harvest of righteousness and peace.
12 So strengthen the hands that hang limp and the knees that give
way,[g] 13 and make level tracks for your feet, so that the limb that is
lame may not be dislocated, but may instead be healed.[h] 14 Strive for
peace with all people, and for holiness, for apart from holiness none
will see the Lord. 15 Watch that no one falls short of God's grace,
and that no "bitter root sprouts up to cause trouble," poisoning many
through it;[i] 16 that no one is sexually immoral or godless like Esau,
who sold his birthright for a single meal.[j] 17 You know that later on,
when he wished to receive the blessing as heir, he was turned away;
he found no room for a change of mind, though he sought the blessing
with tears.[k]
18 You have not come to what can be touched by the hand, to fire that
burns, to darkness, deep gloom and storm,[l] 19 and a trumpet blast and
a voice speaking words, so that the listeners pleaded that nothing
more be said to them. 20 They could not endure the order that was
given: "Even an animal that touches the mountain must be stoned."[m]
21 Indeed, so terrifying was the sight that Moses said, "I am terrified
and trembling."[n] 22 But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city
of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and to myriads of angels
in festal gathering,[o] 23 and to the assembly of the firstborn who are
enrolled in heaven, and to God, the judge of all, and to the spirits
of the righteous made perfect, 24 and to Jesus, who mediates a new

covenant, and to the blood of sprinkling, which speaks better things than Abel's blood.[p]

25 Take care not to reject the one who speaks. If those who rejected him when he gave warning on earth did not get away, much less will we, if we turn our backs on the one who warns us from heaven. 26 His voice shook the earth then, but now he has promised, "Once more I will shake not just the earth but the heavens too."[q] 27 The words "Yet once more" point to the removing of things that are shaken, as things that have been made, so that the things not shaken may endure. 28 Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be grateful, and so offer to God worship that pleases him, with reverence and awe;[r] 29 for our God is a consuming fire.[s]

Notes

- a (12:1) Witnesses: Greek *martyres*, people who testify; here those whose faith is attested in chapter 11. *Clings so closely*: the meaning of the rare Greek word *euperistatos* is uncertain; perhaps "easily distracting." One early papyrus, P46 as reported, reads "easily distracting."
- b (12:2) Leads the way: Greek *archēgos*, "pioneer," "founder"; see 2:10. *For the sake of the joy*: or "instead of the joy."
- c (12:3) Against themselves: so the Westcott–Hort text, following Sinaiticus and other early witnesses as reported; most manuscripts read "against himself."
- d (12:5) Prov 3:11–12 in the Greek Old Testament. *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*; so also in verse 6.
- e (12:6) Punishes … receives: so the Greek Old Testament; the Hebrew reads "as a father the son in whom he delights." *Son*: so throughout this passage the Greek speaks of sons, but the teaching applies to all God's children.
- f (12:9) Human fathers: literally "fathers of our flesh."
- g (12:12) Isa 35:3.
- h (12:13) Prov 4:26 in the Greek Old Testament.
- i (12:15) Deut 29:18 in the Greek Old Testament.
- j (12:16) See Gen 25:29–34.
- k (12:17) Room for a change of mind: literally "place of repentance," perhaps meaning no way to change his father's decision. *Sought the blessing*: or "sought repentance"; the Greek pronoun could refer to either. See Gen 27:30–40.
- l (12:18) What can be touched: later manuscripts read "a mountain that can be touched." See Exod 19:16–22; Deut 4:11; 5:22–26.
- m (12:20) Exod 19:12–13.
- n (12:21) Deut 9:19.

- o (12:22) *Zion*: Hebrew, perhaps “fortress”; the hill of Jerusalem. *Jerusalem*: Hebrew *Yerushalayim*, perhaps “foundation of Shalem” or “foundation of peace.” *Myriads*: literally “tens of thousands.” *Of angels in festal gathering*: or “of angels, to the festal gathering and assembly of the firstborn.”
- p (12:24) Compare Gen 4:10.
- q (12:26) Hag 2:6.
- r (12:28) Let us be grateful: or “let us hold on to grace.”
- s (12:29) Deut 4:24; 9:3.

Chapter 13

1 Let love for one another as brothers continue.[a]
2 Do not forget to welcome strangers, for in doing so some have had
angels as their guests without realizing it.[b]
3 Keep in mind those in prison, as if you shared their chains, and those
who are ill-treated, since you too have bodies of your own.
4 Let marriage be honorable in everyone’s eyes, and the bed of
marriage undefiled; God will bring judgment on the sexually immoral
and on adulterers.
5 Keep your manner of life clear of greed for money, and be satisfied
with what is at hand. For he has said, “I will never let you go, nor will
I ever desert you.”[c]
6 So we may boldly say,

“The Lord is my help; I will have no fear.
What can mortals do to me?”[d]

7 Remember those who led you, who told you God’s word. Look at
how their lives turned out, and follow the example of their faith. 8
Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever. 9 Do not be
swept aside by teachings that are various and foreign. It is a fine thing
for the heart to be made firm by grace, rather than by foods, which
have brought no benefit to those who live by them.[e] 10 We possess an
altar, but the ones who serve at the tent are not allowed to eat from
it. 11 For the bodies of those animals whose blood is brought into the
sanctuary by the high priest as an offering for sin are burned outside
the camp.[f] 12 Therefore Jesus also suffered outside the city gate, to
sanctify the people with his own blood. 13 Let us, then, go out to him
outside the camp, bearing the reproach he bore. 14 We have here no

city that endures; we are searching for the one still to come. 15 Through
him let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the
fruit of lips that confess his name.[g] 16 And do not forget kindness and
sharing, for these are the sacrifices in which God delights.
17 Be obedient to your leaders and defer to them, since they keep watch
over your souls, knowing they must render an account. Let them do
it gladly and not with sighs, for that would bring you no profit. 18 Keep
praying for us. We are persuaded that our conscience is good, since
we wish to conduct ourselves well in every way. 19 I especially ask
you to pray, so that I may be given back to you more quickly.
20 Now may the God of peace, who brought up from the dead the great
shepherd of the sheep by the blood of the eternal covenant, our Lord
Jesus,[h] 21 fit you with all that is good for doing his will, producing in
us what delights him, through Jesus Christ; glory be his forever and
ever. Amen.[i]
22 I urge you, brothers, bear with my word of exhortation, for I have
written to you briefly. 23 You should know that our brother Timothy
has been set free, and if he comes soon, I will see you with him.[j] 24
Give our greetings to all who lead you and to all the saints. Those
from Italy greet you.[k] 25 Grace be with all of you.[l]

Notes

- a (13:1) Love ... as brothers: Greek *philadelphia*.
- b (13:2) Compare Gen 18:1–8; 19:1–3.
- c (13:5) Deut 31:6, 8; Josh 1:5.
- d (13:6) Ps 118:6 (117:6 in the Greek Old Testament). *The Lord*: the Hebrew text has *Yahweh*.
- e (13:9) Foods: probably rules about clean and unclean foods or sacrificial meals.
- f (13:11) Lev 16:27.
- g (13:15) Through him: some manuscripts add “then.” *The fruit of lips*: compare Hos 14:2 in the Greek Old Testament.
- h (13:20) Compare Isa 63:11; Zech 9:11.
- i (13:21) In us: some manuscripts read “in you.”
- j (13:23) *Timothy*: Greek *Timotheos*, “honoring God.” *Set free*: or “has set out.”
- k (13:24) Those from Italy: either people in Italy or Italians living elsewhere; the phrase does not settle where the letter was written.
- l (13:25) With all of you: later manuscripts add “Amen.”

James

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 James,[a] a slave of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the twelve
tribes living scattered abroad: greetings.[b]
2 Count it nothing but joy, my brothers,[c] whenever you run into
trials of many kinds, 3 since you know that the testing of your faith
produces staying power. 4 Let staying power finish its work, so that
you may be mature and whole, lacking in nothing.[d]
5 If any of you is short of wisdom, let him ask God, who gives to
everyone freely and without reproach, and it will be given him. 6 But
let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for the doubter is like a wave
of the sea, blown and tossed by the wind. 7 Such a person must not
suppose that he will get anything from the Lord; 8 he is a man of two
minds, unsteady in all his ways.[e]
9 Let the brother of low standing take pride in being raised up, 10 and
the rich in being brought low, because like a flower of the grass he
will pass away. 11 For the sun comes up with its scorching heat and
withers the grass; its flower drops, and the beauty of its look is lost.
So too the rich man will fade away in the middle of his pursuits.[f]
12 Happy the man who holds out under trial, because once he has stood
the test he will receive the crown of life, which he promised to those
who love him.[g] 13 Let no one say when tempted, "God is tempting me."
For God cannot be tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one.[h]
14 Each person is tempted by being dragged off and lured by his own
desire. 15 Then desire, having conceived, gives birth to sin, and sin,
once full grown, brings forth death.
16 Do not be misled, my dear brothers. 17 Every good gift and every
perfect present is from above, coming down from the Father of lights,
in whom there is no variation or shadow cast by turning.[i] 18 By his

own choice he brought us to birth through the word of truth, so that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures.

19 Know this, my dear brothers: everyone should be swift to hear, unhurried to speak, unhurried to grow angry;[j] 20 for human anger does not accomplish the justice that God requires. 21 Therefore put away all filth and the excess of malice, and with gentleness accept the word planted in you, which is able to save your souls.

22 Be people who do the word, and not only hearers who deceive themselves. 23 For anyone who hears the word and does not do it is like a man who looks at the face he was born with in a mirror; 24 he takes a look at himself, walks off, and straightaway forgets what sort of man he was. 25 But the one who has looked closely into the perfect law, the law of freedom, and stays with it, proving to be no forgetful hearer but a doer who acts, will be happy in what he does.

26 If anyone thinks he is religious and does not put a bridle on his tongue, but deceives his own heart, his religion is worthless. 27 Religion that is pure and unstained before God the Father is this: to look after orphans and widows in their trouble, and to keep oneself unspotted by the world.

Notes

- a (1:1) *James*: Greek *Iakōbos*, from the Hebrew *Yaʿaqov* (Jacob), traditionally explained as "he takes the heel" or "he supplants" (Gen 25:26; 27:36).
- b (1:1) Slave: Greek *doulos*, "slave," "servant." *Living scattered abroad*: literally "in the dispersion" (Greek *diaspora*), the term for Jews living outside the land of Israel, here applied to believers.
- c (1:2) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters; so throughout the letter.
- d (1:4) Mature: Greek *teleios*, "complete," "perfect."
- e (1:8) Of two minds: Greek *dipsychos*, literally "double-souled."
- f (1:11) Scorching heat: or "the scorching wind" (Greek *kausōn*). Compare Isa 40:6–8.
- g (1:12) Happy: or "blessed." *He promised*: later manuscripts read "the Lord promised."
- h (1:13) Tempted: the same Greek word as "trial" in verse 12; it means both testing and temptation.
- i (1:17) Father of lights: that is, the Creator of the heavenly lights. *Shadow cast by turning*: the image is of the shifting shadows of the heavenly bodies.
- j (1:19) Know this: or "You know this." Later manuscripts read "So then."

Chapter 2

1 My brothers, do not hold the faith of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord
of glory, while showing favoritism.[a] 2 Suppose a man comes into your
assembly wearing gold rings and splendid clothes, and a poor man
also comes in, in shabby clothes,[b] 3 and you pay attention to the one
in the splendid clothes and say, "Sit here in this good place," while to
the poor man you say, "You stand there," or, "Sit down on the floor
by my footstool." 4 Have you not made distinctions among yourselves
and become judges with evil reasoning?
5 Listen, my dear brothers. Has not God chosen those who are poor
in the world's eyes to be rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom he
promised to those who love him? 6 But you have treated the poor man
with contempt. Are the rich not the ones who lord it over you, and
the very ones who drag you before the courts? 7 Is it not they who
slander the honorable name that was called over you?[c] 8 If indeed you
carry out the royal law according to the scripture, "You shall love
your neighbor as yourself," you are doing well.[d] 9 But if you show
favoritism, you commit sin, and the law convicts you as transgressors.
10 For whoever keeps the whole law but stumbles on a single point
has become guilty of all of it. 11 The one who said, "Do not commit
adultery," also said, "Do not murder." If you avoid adultery but commit
murder, you have broken the law.[e] 12 Speak and act as people who are
going to be judged by the law of freedom. 13 For judgment is merciless
to the one who has shown no mercy; mercy triumphs over judgment.
14 What good is it, my brothers, if someone claims to have faith but has
no deeds? Can that faith save him?[f] 15 If a brother or sister is without
clothes and short of daily food, 16 and one of you says to them, "Go in
peace; keep warm and eat well," without giving them what the body
requires, what good is that? 17 So it is with faith: on its own, without
deeds, it is a dead thing.
18 But someone will say, "You have faith, and I have deeds." Show
me your faith apart from deeds, and I will show you my faith by
my deeds.[g] 19 You believe that God is one; good for you. Even the
demons believe that, and they shudder.[h] 20 Do you want to be shown,
you empty fellow, that faith without deeds is useless?[i] 21 Was not

Abraham our father declared righteous by deeds, when he offered his
son Isaac on the altar?[j] 22 You see that faith was working along with
his deeds, and by the deeds faith was brought to completion, 23 and
the scripture was fulfilled which says, “Abraham trusted God, and
this was reckoned to him as righteousness”; and he came to be called
the friend of God.[k] 24 You see that a person is declared righteous by
deeds and not by faith alone. 25 And in the same way, was not Rahab
the prostitute also declared righteous by deeds, when she took in the
messengers and sent them off by a different road?[l] 26 For as the body
without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.

Notes

- a (2:1) The Lord of glory: literally “our Lord Jesus Christ of glory”; or “our glorious Lord Jesus Christ.” The Greek may also be read as a question.
- b (2:2) Assembly: Greek *synagōgē*, “gathering,” “synagogue.”
- c (2:7) The honorable name that was called over you: that is, the name of Christ, invoked over believers, perhaps at baptism.
- d (2:8) Lev 19:18.
- e (2:11) Exod 20:13–14; Deut 5:17–18.
- f (2:14) Deeds: Greek *erga*, “works”; so throughout this passage.
- g (2:18) The extent of the objector’s words is uncertain; the quotation may continue further.
- h (2:19) God is one: compare Deut 6:4. Some manuscripts read “there is one God.”
- i (2:20) Useless: Greek *argē*, “idle,” “unproductive.” Later manuscripts read “dead.”
- j (2:21) Gen 22:9–12. *Abraham*: “father of a multitude” (Gen 17:5). *Isaac*: “he laughs.”
- k (2:23) Gen 15:6; compare Isa 41:8; 2 Chr 20:7.
- l (2:25) Josh 2:1–21. *Rahab*: “broad,” “wide.”

Chapter 3

1 Do not let many of you become teachers, my brothers; you are aware
that those of us who teach will face a stricter judgment. 2 Every one
of us trips up in many respects. Whoever never trips up in speech
is a mature man, one able to keep the whole body in check as well.
3 When we put bits into horses’ mouths to make them obey us, we
steer their whole body too.[a] 4 Look at ships as well: large as they are,
and driven by strong winds, they are steered by a very small rudder
wherever the pilot’s impulse wants to go. 5 Just so the tongue is a little
member, yet its boasts are grand. 6 The tongue too is a fire, a whole

world of evil placed among our body parts; it contaminates the entire person, sets the course of life ablaze, and is itself ignited by Gehenna.[b]
7 Every species of wild animal and bird, of reptile and sea creature, is tamed and has been tamed by humankind, 8 but no human being can tame the tongue. It is a restless evil, full of deadly poison.[c] 9 With the tongue we praise the Lord and Father, and with it we curse people who were created in God's likeness.[d] 10 From the same mouth come blessing and curse. My brothers, it should not be this way. 11 Does a spring gush both fresh and bitter water from the same opening? 12 Can a fig tree, my brothers, yield olives, or a vine yield figs? Neither can salt water give fresh.[e]
13 Who among you is wise and understanding? Let him show his deeds by a good way of life, in the gentleness that comes from wisdom. 14 But if you have bitter jealousy and selfish ambition in your hearts, do not boast and lie against the truth. 15 Such wisdom does not descend from above; it belongs to the earth, to the merely natural, to demons.[f]
16 For where jealousy and selfish ambition are, there you find disorder and every vile practice. 17 The wisdom that comes from above, on the other hand, is pure first and foremost, then peace-loving, considerate, willing to yield, brimming with mercy and with good fruit, free of partiality and of pretense. 18 And the fruit of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace.

Notes

- a (3:3) When: later manuscripts read "Look."
- b (3:6) World of wrongdoing: the Greek of this verse is difficult and its punctuation uncertain. *Wheel of existence*: or "the course of life," literally "the wheel of birth." *Gehenna*: the Valley of Hinnom outside Jerusalem, used as a name for the place of final punishment.
- c (3:8) Restless: some manuscripts read "uncontrollable."
- d (3:9) Gen 1:26–27.
- e (3:12) Neither can salt water give fresh: later manuscripts read "So no spring yields both salt water and fresh."
- f (3:15) Merely natural: Greek *psychikē*, "natural," "belonging to the soul" as opposed to the Spirit.

Chapter 4

1 Where do the fights and quarrels among you come from? Do they
not come from your pleasures that wage war in your members?[a]
2 You crave and go without, so you commit murder. You burn with
envy and cannot get what you want, so you battle and wrangle. You
go without because you do not ask.[b]
3 You ask and do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, to
spend it on your pleasures.
4 Adulteresses! Do you not know that friendship with the world is
hostility toward God? So whoever chooses to be a friend of the world
makes himself God's enemy.[c]
5 Or do you think the scripture speaks to no purpose? Does the spirit
he made to dwell in us long with envy?[d]
6 But he gives greater grace. That is why it says,

"God opposes the proud,
but gives grace to the humble."[e]

7 So submit yourselves to God. Stand against the devil, and he will flee
from you. 8 Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you. Wash
your hands, you sinners; purify your hearts, you divided in mind.
9 Be wretched, mourn and weep. Let your laughter be turned into
mourning and your joy into gloom. 10 Humble yourselves before the
Lord, and he will lift you up.
11 Do not speak against one another, brothers. Whoever speaks against
a brother or judges his brother speaks against the law and judges the
law. And if you judge the law, you are not a doer of the law but its
judge. 12 There is one lawgiver and judge, the one able to save and to
destroy. But you, who are you to judge your neighbor?[f]
13 Come now, you who say, "Today or tomorrow we will go into such
and such a city, spend a year there, do business and make money,"
14 when you have no idea what tomorrow holds. What is your life?
You are a vapor that appears briefly and then disappears.[g] 15 Instead
you ought to say, "If the Lord wills, we will live and do this or that."
16 But now you take pride in your boastful schemes. All boasting of that
kind is wicked. 17 Anyone, then, who knows what is good and does
not do it is guilty of sin.

Notes

- a (4:1) Pleasures: Greek *hēdonai*, "desires for pleasure"; so in verse 3.
- b (4:2) Commit murder: some propose the reading "you are jealous" (Greek *phthoneite* for *phoneuete*), but no manuscript is reported to have it.
- c (4:4) Adulteresses: the image is of unfaithfulness to God as unfaithfulness in marriage, as in the prophets. Later manuscripts read "Adulterers and adulteresses."
- d (4:5) The Greek of this verse is difficult, and no Old Testament passage matches it. Other possible renderings: "The spirit that he made to dwell in us yearns jealously," or "He yearns jealously for the spirit that he made to dwell in us."
- e (4:6) Prov 3:34 in the Greek Old Testament.
- f (4:12) One lawgiver and judge: later manuscripts lack "and judge."
- g (4:14) What tomorrow will bring: the Greek is variously read and punctuated in the manuscripts. *You are a mist*: later manuscripts read "It is a mist."

Chapter 5

1 Come now, you rich, weep and howl over the miseries that are coming upon you. 2 Your wealth has rotted, and your clothes have become moth-eaten. 3 Your gold and silver are rusted, and the rust will testify against you and consume your flesh like fire. You have stored up wealth in the final days. 4 Listen! The pay you cheated from the workers who harvested your fields cries out against you, and the shouts of the reapers have come to the ears of the Lord of Armies.[a] 5 You have lived soft lives on earth and indulged yourselves; you have fattened your hearts for the day of slaughter. 6 You have condemned and murdered the righteous one; he does not resist you.[b]

7 Be patient, then, brothers, until the coming of the Lord. See how the farmer waits for the precious crop from the ground, being patient over it until it receives the early and the late rains.[c] 8 You also be patient. Make your hearts firm, for the coming of the Lord is near. 9 Brothers, do not complain about one another, or you may be judged. The judge stands at the door already! 10 Brothers, for a pattern of patient endurance under hardship, look to the prophets who spoke in the Lord's name. 11 We call those who held out happy. You have heard of the endurance of Job, and you have seen the outcome the Lord brought about: the Lord is full of compassion and mercy.[d]

12 Above all, my brothers, do not swear oaths, either by heaven or by
the earth or with any other oath. Let your "yes" be yes and your "no"
be no, so that you do not fall under judgment.[e]
13 Is one of you in trouble? Let him pray. Is one in good spirits? Let
him sing songs of praise. 14 Is someone among you ill? Let that person
summon the church's elders, who should pray over him and anoint
him with oil in the Lord's name.[f] 15 And the prayer offered in faith
will rescue the sick person, and the Lord will raise him up; and if
he has committed sins, he will be forgiven. 16 Confess your sins to
each other and pray for each other, so that you may be healed. A
righteous person's prayer is powerful and effective.[g] 17 Elijah was a
human being with feelings like ours, and he prayed earnestly that it
would not rain, and it did not rain on the land for three years and six
months.[h] 18 Then he prayed again, and the sky gave rain and the land
produced its crop.[i]
19 My brothers, if any one of you wanders from the truth and someone
turns him back, 20 let him know that whoever turns a sinner back from
the error of his way will save his soul from death and will cover a
multitude of sins.[j]

Notes

- a (5:4) Lord of Armies: Greek *kyrios sabaōth*, from the Hebrew *Yahweh tsevaʾot*, "Yahweh of Armies" (traditionally "Lord of hosts"); compare Isa 5:9. The wages were due at the end of each working day (Deut 24:14–15).
- b (5:6) He does not resist you: or, as a question, "Does he not resist you?"
- c (5:7) The early and the late rains: in the land of Israel, the autumn rains after sowing and the spring rains before harvest (Deut 11:14). Westcott and Hort have only "the early and the late"; later manuscripts add "rain," and some add "fruit."
- d (5:11) Happy: or "blessed." *Job*: the meaning of the name is uncertain; it has been explained as "where is the father?" *Full of compassion and mercy*: compare Ps 103:8; Exod 34:6, where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.
- e (5:12) Compare Matt 5:34–37. *Under judgment*: later manuscripts read "into hypocrisy."
- f (5:14) Of the Lord: Westcott and Hort bracket these words; Vaticanus is reported to lack "the Lord."
- g (5:16) As it does its work: or "when it is set in motion."
- h (5:17) 1 Kgs 17:1; 18:1; compare Luke 4:25. *Elijah*: "my God is Yahweh."
- i (5:18) 1 Kgs 18:41–45.

- j (5:20) Let him know: some manuscripts read “know” (plural). *His soul*: that is, probably the sinner’s soul; Westcott and Hort place “his” in the margin, and some manuscripts lack it. Compare Prov 10:12.

1 Peter

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Peter,[a] an apostle of Jesus Christ, to God's chosen ones living as
foreigners scattered through Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia and
Bithynia,[b] 2 whom God the Father chose as he knew beforehand, set
apart by the Spirit to obey Jesus Christ and to be sprinkled with his
blood. Grace and peace be multiplied to you.[c]
3 Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! Because
of his abundant mercy he has given us a new birth into a living
hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, 4 to an
inheritance that cannot decay or be defiled or fade, kept safe in the
heavens for you, 5 you who are protected by God's power through
faith until the arrival of salvation, prepared to be revealed when time
comes to its close. 6 In this you are overjoyed, even though now for a
little while, if it must be, you have been grieved by trials of various
kinds, 7 Their purpose is that your faith, once proven genuine, a thing
of greater value than gold (which perishes, though fire tests it), may
bring praise and glory and honor at the unveiling of Jesus Christ. 8 You
have not seen him, yet you love him; and though you do not see him
now, you trust him and are overjoyed with a joy beyond words and
filled with glory,[d] 9 as you receive the goal of your faith, the salvation
of your souls.
10 Concerning this salvation the prophets who spoke beforehand of
the grace meant for you searched and inquired with care, 11 They
probed what person or what period the Spirit of Christ in them meant,
when it bore witness ahead of time to the sufferings Christ would
undergo and the glories that would come after them. 12 To them it
was disclosed that their ministry was not for their own benefit but
for yours, in those matters now reported to you by the ones who

preached the gospel to you through the Holy Spirit sent from heaven;
into these things angels yearn to peer.
13 So gird up the loins of your mind, keep sober, and set your hope
fully on the grace that is being brought to you when Jesus Christ
is unveiled.[e] 14 As obedient children, do not shape yourselves to the
desires you once had in your ignorance. 15 Rather, as the one who
called you is holy, become holy yourselves in all your conduct, 16 since
it is written, "You shall be holy, because I am holy."[f]
17 And if you call on him as Father who judges each person's work
impartially, live out the time of your stay as foreigners in reverent
fear, 18 knowing that it was not with perishable things like silver or
gold that you were ransomed from the empty way of life handed
down from your ancestors, 19 but with precious blood, as of a lamb
without blemish or spot, the blood of Christ. 20 He was chosen before
the world was founded but appeared in the final period of time for
your benefit, 21 who through him trust in God, who raised him from
the dead and gave him glory, so that your faith and hope are in God.
22 Now that you have purified your souls by obeying the truth, so as to
have a sincere love for the brothers, love one another earnestly from
the heart,[g]
23 You have been begotten again from seed that does not perish rather
than seed that does, by means of God's word, which lives and abides.
24 For

"all humankind is grass,
and all its splendor like a wildflower.
The grass dries up,
and the flower falls,
25 but what the Lord has spoken stands for all time."

That spoken word is the gospel which was preached to you.[h]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Peter*: Greek *Petros*, "rock," "stone," the name Jesus gave to Simon (John 1:42), the Greek equivalent of Aramaic *Kēphas*.
- b (1:1) Living as foreigners scattered: literally "sojourners of the dispersion" (Greek *diaspora*). The places named are Roman provinces in what is now Turkey.
- c (1:2) Sprinkled with his blood: compare Exod 24:7–8.

- d (1:8) Not seen him: later manuscripts read “not known him.”
- e (1:13) Gird up the loins of your mind: the image is of tucking up a long robe to be ready for action.
- f (1:16) Lev 11:44–45; 19:2. Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek word introducing the quotation.
- g (1:22) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, here in the compound *philadelphia*, “love of brothers,” which includes sisters. *From the heart*: some manuscripts read “from a pure heart.” Later manuscripts add “through the Spirit” after “the truth.”
- h (1:25) Isa 40:6–8 in the Greek Old Testament, where the Hebrew reads “the word of our God.”

Chapter 2

1 So put away all malice and all deceit, hypocrisy, envy and all slander.
2 As babies just born crave milk, crave the unadulterated milk of the
word, so that you may be nourished by it and grow toward salvation,[a]
3 if indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good.[b]
4 Come to him, a living stone rejected by people but chosen and
precious in God’s sight,
5 and you yourselves, like living stones, are being built up as a spiritual
house, to be a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable
to God through Jesus Christ.
6 For scripture contains this:

> “See, I set down in Zion a stone,
> a cornerstone, chosen, of great worth;
> whoever puts his trust in him will never be disgraced.”[c]

7 So for you who believe, he is precious; but for those who refuse to
believe,

> “the stone the builders threw away
> has become the cornerstone,”[d]

8 and

> “a stone over which they stumble,
> a rock that makes them fall.”

They stumble by refusing to obey the word, and to this end they were appointed.[e]
9 But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people
God has made his own, so that you may declare the excellencies of
the one who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.[f] 10

You were once "not a people," and now you are the people of God;
you were "shown no mercy," and now mercy has been shown you.[g]
11 Dear friends, I appeal to you as foreigners and exiles to keep away
from the desires of the flesh, which wage war against the soul. 12 Let
your way of life among the nations be honorable, so that in the very
matter in which they accuse you of evildoing they may observe your
fine actions and give glory to God on the day of his coming.[h]
13 For the Lord's sake submit to every human institution, whether to
the emperor as supreme,[i] 14 or to governors as sent by him to punish
wrongdoers and to praise those who do good. 15 It is God's purpose
that by your good conduct you muzzle the ignorant talk of senseless
people. 16 Live as free people, yet not using your freedom as a cover for
evil, but as slaves of God. 17 Show honor to all. Love the brotherhood.
Revere God. Give the emperor his due honor.[j]
18 Slaves, accept the authority of your masters with complete respect,
whether they are gentle and fair or harsh.[k]
19 For it is a mark of grace when someone, because he is conscious of
God, endures pain while suffering unjustly.
20 What credit is there if you endure a beating for doing wrong? But if
you endure suffering when you do good, this is grace in God's sight.
21 For it was to this that you were called, since Christ also suffered
for you, leaving you an example so that you should follow in his
footsteps.[l]
22 "No sin did he commit,
nor was any lie detected on his lips."[m]
23 Reviled, he hurled back no abuse; suffering, he made no threats;
instead he left his cause with the one whose judgment is just.
24 In his own body he bore our sins up onto the tree, so that we, having
parted from sins, might live to righteousness. By his bruises you have
been made whole.[n]
25 For you were straying like sheep, but now you have returned to the
shepherd and guardian of your souls.[o]

Notes

- a (2:2) Of the word: or "spiritual" (Greek *logikon*). *Into salvation*: later manuscripts omit these words.

- b (2:3) Ps 34:8 (Greek Old Testament 33:9), where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.
- c (2:6) Isa 28:16 in the Greek Old Testament.
- d (2:7) Ps 118:22 (Greek Old Testament 117:22). *There is honor*: or “he is precious.”
- e (2:8) Isa 8:14.
- f (2:9) Exod 19:5–6; Isa 43:20–21. *Excellencies*: or “praises,” “mighty deeds.”
- g (2:10) Compare Hos 1:6, 9; 2:23.
- h (2:12) Nations: or “Gentiles,” here meaning those who do not know God. *The day of his coming*: literally “the day of visitation.”
- i (2:13) Emperor: Greek *basileus*, “king,” the usual title for the Roman emperor in the Greek-speaking east.
- j (2:17) Brotherhood: Greek *adelphotēs*, the community of believers.
- k (2:18) Household servants: Greek *oiketai*, slaves in a household.
- l (2:21) Suffered: some manuscripts read “died.”
- m (2:22) Isa 53:9.
- n (2:24) Isa 53:4–5, 12. *Tree*: that is, the cross.
- o (2:25) Isa 53:6. *Guardian*: Greek *episkopos*, “overseer.”

Chapter 3

1 Wives, likewise, be subject to your husbands, so that if any of
them refuse to believe the message, they may be won without words
through the way their wives live, 2 when they see your pure and
reverent conduct. 3 Do not let your beauty be the outward kind,
braided hair and gold ornaments and fine clothing, 4 Let it rather be
the inner self hidden in the heart, adorned with the lasting beauty of a
meek and tranquil spirit, which God counts as costly. 5 For this is how
the holy women of old who hoped in God used to adorn themselves,
submitting to their own husbands, 6 as Sarah obeyed Abraham, calling
him lord. You have become her daughters if you do good and do not
give way to fear.[a]
7 In the same way, husbands, live with your wives considerately,
honoring the woman as the more delicate partner, because they too
are co-heirs of the gift of life, so that nothing will block your prayers.
8 Finally, all of you, be of one mind, sympathetic, loving as brothers,
tenderhearted and humble.
9 Do not repay evil for evil or insult for insult, but bless instead,
because it was for this that you were called, so that you may inherit
a blessing.

10 For
"whoever wants to love life
and see good days
must keep his tongue from evil
and his lips from speaking deceit;
11 let him shun evil and do right;
let him look for peace and go after it.
12 For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous,
and his ears are open to their prayer;
but the face of the Lord is against those who do evil."[b]
13 And who will do you harm if you are zealous for the good? 14 Yet even if you have to suffer because you do right, you are happy. "Have no fear of them, and do not be shaken,"[c] 15 but in your hearts revere Christ as holy, as Lord, and be prepared at all times to make a defense to anyone who asks you to account for your hope,[d] 16 yet doing it with gentleness and reverence, keeping a good conscience, so that when you are slandered, those who abuse your good conduct in Christ may be put to shame. 17 It is better, should God so will, to suffer for doing right than to suffer for doing wrong. 18 Christ also suffered for sins once and for all, an upright person for the unrighteous, in order to lead you to God. He was killed in the body but brought to life by the spirit,[e] 19 in which he went also to the spirits held in prison and preached to them,[f] 20 who refused to obey long ago, while God waited patiently in Noah's time as the ark was under construction. Only a few, eight people, were rescued through the water.[g] 21 And baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you also, not as a removal of dirt from the flesh but as the pledge of a good conscience toward God, through the resurrection of Jesus Christ,[h] 22 He has passed into heaven and sits at God's right hand, and angels and authorities and powers have been placed under him.

Notes

- a (3:6) Gen 18:12. *Sarah*: "princess." *Abraham*: "father of a multitude." *Give way to fear*: compare Prov 3:25.
- b (3:12) Ps 34:12–16 (Greek Old Testament 33:13–17), where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.

- c (3:14) Isa 8:12. *Have no fear of them*: literally “do not fear their fear,” that is, either what they fear or the fear they cause. *Happy*: or “blessed.”
- d (3:15) Isa 8:13, where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*. Later manuscripts read “the Lord God” in place of “Christ as Lord.”
- e (3:18) Died: Westcott and Hort read *apethanen*, “died,” with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus as reported; many manuscripts read *epathen*, “suffered.” *You*: some manuscripts read “us.” *In the spirit*: or “by the Spirit.”
- f (3:19) In which: or “in whom,” that is, in the spirit. The passage is much debated. The spirits have been understood as the fallen angels of Gen 6:1–4 (compare 2 Pet 2:4; Jude 6 and the book of 1 Enoch), as the dead of Noah’s generation, or as those to whom Christ spoke through Noah; the proclamation as either a message of victory or the good news (compare 4:6).
- g (3:20) Gen 6–8. *Noah*: “rest.”
- h (3:21) Corresponds to this: Greek *antitypon*, “antitype,” “counterpart.” *Pledge*: or “appeal” (Greek *eperōtēma*).

Chapter 4

1 So, since Christ has suffered in the flesh, you too must arm yourselves with that same resolve, because the one who has suffered in
the flesh has broken with sin,[a] 2 so as to live the rest of his time in the
flesh no longer for human desires but for the will of God. 3 For the
time already past is enough for doing what the Gentiles want to do,
living in debauchery, lusts, drunkenness, wild parties, drinking bouts
and lawless idolatry. 4 They are surprised that you do not plunge with
them into the same flood of reckless living, and they abuse you; 5 but
they will answer to the one prepared to judge both the living and the
dead. 6 For this is why the good news was proclaimed even to the
dead, that though they had been judged in the flesh as human beings
are, they might live in the spirit as God does.
7 The end of all things has drawn near. So be sensible and sober for
the sake of your prayers. 8 Above all, keep your love for one another
constant, since love covers a multitude of sins.[b] 9 Be hospitable to one
another without grumbling. 10 Each of you has received a gift; employ
it to serve one another, like faithful managers of God’s many-sided
grace: 11 if you speak, speak as if delivering God’s own words; if you
serve, serve with the strength God provides, so that God may receive
honor in all you do through Jesus Christ. Glory and might are his
forever and ever. Amen.

12 Dear friends, do not be bewildered by the blaze of trial that has come
among you to test you, as if something unheard of were befalling you.
13 But to the extent that you share the sufferings of Christ, rejoice, so
that you may also rejoice and be overjoyed when his glory is revealed.
14 If you are insulted for the name of Christ, you are blessed, because
the Spirit of glory, the Spirit of God, rests on you.[c]
15 But let none of you suffer as a murderer or thief or evildoer or as a
meddler.
16 But if anyone suffers as a Christian, he should not be ashamed but
should glorify God in that name.[d]
17 For it is time for the judgment to start with God's own household;
and if it starts with us, how will it end for those who refuse to obey
God's good news?[e]
18 And

> "if it is hard for the righteous to be saved,
> where will the godless and the sinner appear?"[f]

19 Let those, then, who suffer as God wills commit their souls to the
Creator, who is faithful, and go on doing good.

Notes

- a (4:1) In the flesh: later manuscripts add "for us" after "suffered."
- b (4:8) Prov 10:12.
- c (4:14) Compare Isa 11:2. Later manuscripts add "and of power" after "glory," and some add "On their part he is blasphemed, but on your part he is glorified."
- d (4:16) Christian: Greek *Christianos*, "follower of Christ"; compare Acts 11:26; 26:28. *In that name*: later manuscripts read "in this respect."
- e (4:17) It is time: Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek article before "time."
- f (4:18) Prov 11:31 in the Greek Old Testament.

Chapter 5

1 To the elders among you, then, I make my appeal, as one who is an
elder with you, who witnessed Christ's sufferings and will share also
in the glory soon to be disclosed: 2 shepherd the flock of God among
you, watching over it not under compulsion but willingly, as God
would have it, not for shameful gain but eagerly,[a] 3 not domineering
over the portions allotted to you, but setting a pattern for the flock.

4 Then when the head shepherd is made manifest, you will win the
crown of glory that never withers.
5 Likewise, you younger ones, be subject to those who are older. All
of you, tie on humility like an apron in dealing with each other, for
"God sets himself against the arrogant,
but to the lowly he gives grace."[b]
6 So bow down beneath God's powerful hand, so that at the right
moment he may raise you up,
7 casting all your anxiety on him, because he cares for you.[c]
8 Stay sober and alert. The devil, your opponent, roams about like a
lion roaring in search of someone to swallow.
9 Resist him, firm in the faith, knowing that the same kinds of suffer-
ing are being laid on your family of believers throughout the world.[d]
10 And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who
called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, establish,
strengthen and settle you.
11 To him be the power forever. Amen.
12 With the help of Silvanus, whom I consider a trustworthy brother,
I have written you this short letter to encourage you and to affirm
that this is God's true grace. Hold your ground in it.[e] 13 She who is in
Babylon, chosen together with you, sends you greetings, and so does
Mark my son.[f] 14 Greet one another with a kiss of love. Peace to all of
you who are in Christ.[g]

Notes

- a (5:2) Watching over it: some manuscripts lack these words. *As God would have it*: some manuscripts lack these words.
- b (5:5) Prov 3:34 in the Greek Old Testament.
- c (5:7) Compare Ps 55:22 (Greek Old Testament 54:23).
- d (5:9) Family of believers: Greek *adelphotēs*, "brotherhood."
- e (5:12) *Silvanus*: a Latin name, perhaps from *silva*, "forest"; probably the Silas of Acts 15:22–40. *Through Silvanus*: that is, either as secretary or as bearer of the letter.
- f (5:13) *She who is in Babylon*: probably the church in Rome, called by the name of the ancient capital of exile; compare Rev 17:5. *Mark*: Latin *Marcus*, perhaps "of Mars"; compare Acts 12:12.
- g (5:14) Later manuscripts add "Jesus. Amen."

2 Peter

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ, to those who have
received a faith as precious as ours through the fairness of our God
and Savior Jesus Christ:[a] 2 grace and peace be multiplied to you in the
knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord.
3 His divine power has granted us all that we need for life and
devotion, through knowing the one who summoned us by his own
splendor and moral excellence.[b] 4 By these means he has given us
promises of great value and greatness, so that by them you might
become partakers of the divine nature, having fled the decay that
lust has spread through the world. 5 For this very reason, make every
effort to add excellence to your faith, and knowledge to excellence,
6 and self-control to knowledge, and endurance to self-control, and
godliness to endurance, 7 and affection for the brothers to godliness,
and love to affection for the brothers.[c] 8 If these qualities are yours
and keep increasing, they keep you from being idle or fruitless in the
knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. 9 Whoever lacks them is blind,
shortsighted, having forgotten that he was cleansed from his past
sins. 10 So, brothers and sisters, work even harder to make your calling
and choice certain; if you do these things, you will never fall. 11 For in
this way entry into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus
Christ will be richly furnished for you.
12 That is why I mean to keep reminding you of these things, though
you know them and are established in the truth you now have. 13 I
think it right, as long as I am in this tent, to stir you up by way of
reminder,[d] 14 since I know that the putting off of my tent will come
soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ also made clear to me.[e] 15 And I will be
diligent to make sure that, once I have gone, you can call these things
to mind whenever you need.[f]

16 For it was not cleverly invented myths that we followed when we
made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ;
we were eyewitnesses of his majesty. 17 He received honor and glory
from God the Father when the Majestic Glory spoke to him: "This is
my beloved Son, with whom I am delighted."[g] 18 We ourselves heard
this voice carried from heaven when we were with him on the holy
mountain. 19 And we have the prophetic word made more certain, and
you do well to pay attention to it as to a lamp shining in a dark place,
until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts.[h] 20
Know this first of all, that no prophecy of scripture comes from one's
own interpretation. 21 No prophecy ever came about because a human
being willed it; rather, borne along by the Holy Spirit, human beings
spoke as messengers from God.[i]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Simon*: Greek form of the Hebrew *Shimʿon*, "he has heard." Some manuscripts read *Symeōn*, "Simeon," the form closer to the Hebrew. *Peter*: "rock." *Our God and Savior Jesus Christ*: or "our God and the Savior Jesus Christ."
- b (1:3) By his own glory and excellence: some manuscripts read "to glory and excellence." *Excellence*: Greek *aretē*, "virtue," "moral excellence."
- c (1:7) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, here in the compound *philadelphia*, which includes sisters.
- d (1:13) Tent: that is, the body; compare 2 Cor 5:1, 4.
- e (1:14) Compare John 21:18–19.
- f (1:15) Gone: Greek *exodos*, "departure," "exodus," here meaning death.
- g (1:17) Compare Matt 17:5; Mark 9:7; Luke 9:35. *Majestic Glory*: a reverent way of referring to God.
- h (1:19) Morning star: Greek *phōsphoros*, "light-bringer," the planet Venus seen before dawn.
- i (1:21) Human beings spoke as messengers from God: some manuscripts read "holy people of God spoke."

Chapter 2

1 But false prophets also appeared among the people, and likewise
false teachers will arise among you. They will quietly introduce
destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them,
bringing swift destruction on themselves.[a] 2 Many will take up their
licentious ways, and through them the way of the truth will be
brought into disrepute. 3 In their greed they will exploit you with

fabricated words. Their condemnation, pronounced long ago, is not idle, and their destruction is not asleep.
4 For if God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into Tartarus and committed them to pits of gloom to be kept until the judgment;[b] 5 if he did not hold back from punishing the world of old, but kept Noah safe, a preacher of righteousness, together with seven others, when he let loose the flood upon a godless world;[c] 6 if by reducing the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to ashes he condemned them, making them an example of what is coming for the ungodly;[d] 7 and if he rescued righteous Lot, who was worn down by the debauched conduct of lawless people[e] 8 (that good man, dwelling in their midst, was in anguish of soul from day to day at the lawless acts he witnessed and heard of), 9 then the Lord is well able to deliver the devout out of testing and to hold the wicked in custody for punishment on the day of judgment, 10 and above all those who chase after the flesh with polluted craving and treat lordship with contempt.
¶Insolent and headstrong, they have no fear in reviling the glorious ones,[f] 11 whereas angels, though greater in strength and power, do not bring a blasphemous judgment against them before the Lord.[g] 12 These people, though, are like brute beasts, mere creatures of nature, born to be trapped and killed; they rail at what they know nothing about, and like those beasts they will perish in their corruption, 13 being wronged as the reward of their own wrong. Indulgence in broad daylight is their idea of pleasure. They are spots and disgraces, luxuriating in their deceits even as they share your table.[h] 14 Their eyes are full of an adulteress and never stop sinning. They lure the unsteady. Their hearts are well practiced in greed. Children under a curse! 15 They have left the straight path and wandered off, following the path of Balaam son of Beor, who loved payment for wickedness,[i] 16 but he was taken to task for his offense: a dumb beast of burden spoke in a man's voice and checked the prophet's folly.
17 These people are dried-up springs and clouds blown by a gale. The deepest darkness is kept in store for them.[j] 18 For, uttering loud boasts of folly, they entice by sensual desires of the flesh those who are barely escaping from people who live in error. 19 Freedom is what they

offer, while they are themselves in bondage to decay; for a person is the slave of whatever has mastered him. 20 For if they have escaped the world's corruptions by knowing our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, and then become entangled in them again and are defeated, their final condition is worse than their first.[k] 21 Better for them never to have come to know the road of righteousness than to know it and then turn their backs on the holy command handed down to them. 22 In them the true proverb has come to pass: "The dog has gone back to what it threw up," and, "The washed pig has gone back to roll in the mud."[l]

Notes

- a (2:1) Heresies: or "factions." *Master*: Greek *despotēs*.
- b (2:4) Tartarus: in Greek myth, the deepest part of the underworld, where rebellious powers were confined; compare 1 Enoch 10:4–6; 20:2. *Pits*: Westcott and Hort read *sirois*, "pits," with Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and Vaticanus as reported; other manuscripts read *seirais*, "chains."
- c (2:5) Gen 6–8. *Noah*: "rest." *With seven others*: literally "as the eighth."
- d (2:6) Gen 19:24–28. *Sodom* and *Gomorrah*: the meanings of the names are uncertain. *Of what is coming for the ungodly*: some manuscripts read "to those who would live ungodly lives."
- e (2:7) *Lot*: perhaps "covering."
- f (2:10) Glorious ones: Greek *doxai*, "glories," probably angelic beings.
- g (2:11) Before the Lord: Westcott and Hort bracket these words; some manuscripts lack them. Compare Jude 9.
- h (2:13) Being wronged: Westcott and Hort read *adikoumenoi* with P72 and Vaticanus as reported; many manuscripts read *komioumenoi*, "receiving." *Deceptions*: some manuscripts read "love feasts," as in Jude 12.
- i (2:15) Num 22–24. *Balaam*: of uncertain meaning, perhaps "devourer." *Beor*: perhaps "burning." Some manuscripts read *Bosor*.
- j (2:17) Later manuscripts add "forever."
- k (2:20) Compare Matt 12:45; Luke 11:26.
- l (2:22) Prov 26:11. The second saying is not from the Old Testament; a similar proverb appears in the story of Ahiqar.

Chapter 3

1 Dear friends, this is already my second letter to you, and in each I aim to rouse your pure minds by reminding you,[a] 2 so that you will recall what the holy prophets said long ago and the command of the Lord and Savior delivered by your apostles. 3 Above all, understand this: in the final days mockers will come, ridiculing and following

their own desires, [4] and saying, “Where is the promise of his coming? Since the fathers fell asleep, everything goes on as it has since the beginning of creation.”[b] [5] For they deliberately overlook this fact, that long ago the heavens existed and the earth was formed out of water and through water by the word of God,[c] [6] and that through these the world of that time was flooded with water and perished. [7] But by the same word the present heavens and earth are being stored up for fire, kept until the day of judgment and destruction of the ungodly.

[8] Dear friends, do not let this one thing escape your notice: with the Lord a single day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as a single day.[d] [9] The Lord is not slow to keep his promise, as some reckon slowness. He is patient toward you, not wanting anyone to be lost, but wanting all to find their way to repentance.[e] [10] But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and on it the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the elements will be dissolved with burning heat, and the earth and the works in it will be found.[f]

[11] Seeing that all these things are thus to be broken up, what kind of people must you be, living holy and godly lives,[g] [12] as you look for the day of God and speed its coming! On account of that day the heavens will be destroyed by fire, and the elements will melt away in the blaze.[h] [13] But according to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth, in which righteousness is at home.[i]

[14] So, dear friends, since you are waiting for these things, be eager to be found by him without spot or blemish, at peace. [15] Regard our Lord’s patience as your opportunity for salvation, as Paul too, our dear brother, has written to you with the wisdom granted to him,[j] [16] speaking of these matters as he does in every one of his letters. Some points in them are difficult to grasp, and untaught and unsteady people distort them, as they distort the rest of the scriptures, to their own ruin. [17] Since you have been forewarned, then, dear friends, watch yourselves, lest you be swept off by the error of the lawless and fall from your own secure position. [18] But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity.[k]

Notes

- a (3:1) Second letter: perhaps referring to 1 Peter.
- b (3:4) The fathers: perhaps the ancestors of Israel, or the first generation of believers. *Fell asleep*: that is, died.
- c (3:5) Gen 1:2, 6–9.
- d (3:8) Ps 90:4 (Greek Old Testament 89:4).
- e (3:9) Toward you: some manuscripts read “for your sake,” and later manuscripts “toward us.”
- f (3:10) Like a thief: compare Matt 24:43; 1 Thess 5:2. *Will be found*: Westcott and Hort read *heurethēsetai* with Sinaiticus and Vaticanus as reported, perhaps meaning “will be laid bare” before God’s judgment; they suspected an early error. Later manuscripts read “will be burned up”; others have “will not be found” or “will vanish.”
- g (3:11) You: Westcott and Hort bracket this word.
- h (3:12) Speed its coming: or “earnestly desire its coming.”
- i (3:13) Isa 65:17; 66:22.
- j (3:15) *Paul*: Latin *Paulus*, “small.”
- k (3:18) Later manuscripts add “Amen.”

1 John

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 What existed from the beginning, what we have heard, what our
own eyes have seen, what we gazed on and our hands handled,
concerning the word of life:[a] 2 The life was disclosed; we have seen it,
we testify to it, and we report to you that eternal life which was in the
Father's presence and was disclosed to us. 3 We announce to you also
what we have seen and heard, so that you too may have a common
life with us; and our common life is with the Father and with his Son
Jesus Christ.[b] 4 We write this so that the joy we share may be full.[c]
5 This is the message we have heard from him and pass on to you:
God is light, and in him there is no darkness whatever. 6 If we claim
to have fellowship with him while we walk in the darkness, we are
lying and are not living out the truth. 7 But if we walk in the light as
he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood
of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin.[d] 8 If we say we have no sin,
we deceive ourselves, and there is no truth within us. 9 If we confess
our sins, he is faithful and just, so that he forgives us our sins and
cleanses us from all wrongdoing. 10 If we say we have never sinned,
we make him out to be a liar, and his message is not in us.

Notes

- a (1:1) Word of life: Greek *logos*, "word," "message"; compare John 1:1–4.
- b (1:3) Fellowship: Greek *koinōnia*, "sharing," "partnership."
- c (1:4) The joy we share: literally "our joy"; many manuscripts read "your joy." *We write*: later manuscripts read "we write to you."
- d (1:7) Jesus: later manuscripts read "Jesus Christ."

Chapter 2

1 My little children, I am writing these things to you so that you may
not sin. But if anyone does sin, we have an advocate with the Father,

Jesus Christ the righteous one.[a] 2 He himself is the atoning sacrifice for
our sins, and not for ours alone but also for those of the whole world.[b]
3 And by this we can be sure that we have come to know him: if we
keep his commandments. 4 Anyone who claims, "I know him," yet
ignores what he commands is lying, and the truth has no place in
such a person. 5 Whoever keeps to his word, though, is someone in
whom God's love has truly reached its goal. This is how we can tell
we are in him: 6 whoever says he remains in him ought himself to
walk as that one walked.[c]
7 Dear friends, it is no new commandment I am writing to you, but
an old commandment, which you have had from the beginning. The
old commandment is the word you have heard.[d] 8 Yet I am writing to
you a new commandment, which is true in him and in you, because
the darkness is passing away and the true light is already shining. 9
Whoever says he is in the light but hates his brother is still in the
darkness.[e] 10 Whoever loves his brother remains in the light, and there
is nothing in him to make him stumble. 11 But whoever hates his
brother is in the darkness and walks in the darkness, and does not
know where he is going, because the darkness has blinded his eyes.
12 I am writing to you, little children,
because your sins have been forgiven for his name's sake.
13 I am writing to you, fathers,
because you know him who is from the beginning.
I am writing to you, young men,
because you have overcome the evil one.
I have written to you, children,
because you know the Father.[f]
14 I have written to you, fathers,
because you know him who is from the beginning.
I have written to you, young men,
because you are strong,
and the word of God remains in you,
and you have overcome the evil one.[g]
15 Do not love the world or the things in the world. If anyone loves
the world, the love of the Father is not in him. 16 For everything in

the world, the craving of the flesh and the craving of the eyes and the arrogance of life, is not from the Father but from the world.[h] 17 And the world is passing away, and its craving, but whoever does the will of God remains forever.[i]

18 Children, it is the last hour; and as you heard that antichrist is coming, so now many antichrists have arisen. That is how we know that it is the last hour.[j] 19 They went out from us, but they did not belong to us; for if they had belonged to us, they would have stayed with us. But they went out so that it might be made plain that none of them belong to us. 20 But you have an anointing from the Holy One, and you all know.[k] 21 My reason for writing is not that the truth is unknown to you, but that you know it, and that no falsehood has its source in the truth. 22 Who is a liar if not the one who says Jesus is not the Christ? Such a person, disowning both Father and Son, is the antichrist. 23 No one who denies the Son has the Father either; whoever confesses the Son has the Father too.[l] 24 Let the message you heard from the beginning stay in you. If it stays in you, you also will stay in the Son and in the Father.[m] 25 And the promise he has given us is this: life eternal.

26 What I have written here concerns those who would mislead you. 27 But you have the anointing you received from him remaining in you, and so you need no one to instruct you. His anointing instructs you in all things; it is genuine and no falsehood. So, as it has instructed you, remain in him.[n]

28 And now, my little ones, remain in him, so that when he is revealed we may stand unafraid and not turn from him ashamed when he comes.[o] 29 Since you know that he is just, be sure of this too: every person who practices justice is his offspring.

Notes

- a (2:1) Advocate: Greek *paraklētos*, “one called alongside,” “helper,” the word used of the Spirit in John 14:16.
- b (2:2) Atoning sacrifice: Greek *hilasmos*, “means of atonement,” “propitiation,” “expiation.”
- c (2:6) Remains: Greek *menein*, “remain,” “remain,” “dwell,” a key word of this letter.

- d (2:7) Dear friends: literally “beloved ones.” Later manuscripts read “Brothers.” *You have heard*: later manuscripts add “from the beginning.”
- e (2:9) Brother: that is, a fellow believer, whether brother or sister; so throughout the letter.
- f (2:13) I have written: some manuscripts read “I am writing.” In verses 13–14 the verb changes from present to past tense, perhaps for variety, perhaps referring to this letter or an earlier one.
- g (2:14) Of God: Westcott and Hort bracket these words.
- h (2:16) Arrogance of life: or “pride in possessions”; Greek *bios* can mean “life” or “livelihood.”
- i (2:17) Its craving: Westcott and Hort bracket “its.”
- j (2:18) Antichrist: Greek *antichristos*, “opponent of Christ” or “one in place of Christ”; in the New Testament the word occurs only in 1 and 2 John.
- k (2:20) You all know: many manuscripts read “you know all things.” *Anointing*: Greek *chrisma*, related to *Christos*, “anointed one.”
- l (2:23) Whoever confesses the Son has the Father too: later manuscripts omit this sentence.
- m (2:24) In the Father: Westcott and Hort bracket “in.”
- n (2:27) Remain in him: or “you remain in him.”
- o (2:28) Comes: Greek *parousia*, “arrival,” “presence.”

Chapter 3

1 Look how great a love the Father has lavished on us, that we are named God’s children; and that is what we are! The world fails to recognize us for this reason: it failed to recognize him.[a] 2 Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will become has not yet been made clear. We do know that when he is revealed we will be like him, because we will see him just as he is.[b] 3 And everyone who has this hope set on him purifies himself, as he is pure.

4 Everyone who commits sin also commits lawlessness; sin is lawlessness. 5 You know that he appeared in order to take away sins, and in him there is no sin.[c] 6 Whoever remains in him does not go on in sin; whoever goes on in sin has neither seen nor known him. 7 Little children, let no one lead you astray. Whoever does what is right is righteous, just as he is righteous. 8 The one who keeps on sinning belongs to the devil, since the devil has sinned from the start. The Son of God appeared for this reason: to demolish the devil’s work.[d] 9 A person begotten by God does not practice sin, since God’s seed

remains in him; indeed he is unable to go on sinning, since God is his father.[e] 10 Here is what shows who are God's children and who are the devil's: anyone who fails to practice justice is not God's, and the same is true of anyone who fails to love his brother.
11 For this is the message you have heard from the beginning, that we should love one another, 12 Do not be like Cain, who came from the evil one and cut his brother's throat. Why did he kill him? Because what he did was wicked, while what his brother did was upright.[f] 13 Do not be surprised, brothers, if the world hates you.[g] 14 We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers. Whoever does not love remains in death.[h] 15 Everyone who hates his brother is a murderer, and you know that no murderer has eternal life remaining in him. 16 By this we have come to know love, that he laid down his life for us; and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers. 17 Whoever has this world's means of life and notices a brother in want, yet shuts off his compassion from him, how can God's love be remaining in such a one?[i] 18 Little children, let us love not in word or with the tongue but in deed and in truth.
19 This is how we will know that we belong to the truth, and we will set our hearts at rest in his presence[j] 20 whenever our heart condemns us, because God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything.
21 Dear friends, if our heart does not condemn us, we have confidence before God, 22 and whatever we ask we receive from him, because we keep his commandments and do what pleases him. 23 And this is his commandment, that we should believe in the name of his Son Jesus Christ and love one another, just as he commanded us. 24 The one who obeys what God commands remains in God, and God in that person. And here is how we know he remains in us: by the Spirit he gave us.

Notes

- a (3:1) That is what we are: later manuscripts omit these words.
- b (3:2) When he appears: or "when it is revealed."
- c (3:5) Sins: later manuscripts read "our sins."
- d (3:8) Devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer."
- e (3:9) God's seed: literally "his seed"; perhaps God's nature or his word.
- f (3:12) Gen 4:1–16. *Cain*: perhaps "acquired" (Gen 4:1), or "smith."
- g (3:13) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters.

- h (3:14) Whoever does not love: later manuscripts add “his brother.”
- i (3:17) Compassion: literally “inward parts.”
- j (3:19) Reassure: or “persuade.” *Our hearts*: literally “our heart”; so in verses 20–21.

Chapter 4

1 Dear friends, do not trust every spirit; put the spirits to the test,
whether they come from God, since many false prophets have gone
forth into the world. 2 By this you know the Spirit of God: every spirit
that confesses Jesus Christ as having come in the flesh is from God, 3
But any spirit that refuses to confess Jesus does not come from God.
That spirit belongs to the antichrist; you were told it was on its way,
and already it is here in the world.[a] 4 You, little ones, come from God,
and you have defeated them, since the one in you is mightier than
the one in the world. 5 Those people belong to the world, so the world
is the source of their talk, and the world gives them a hearing. 6 We
come from God. Anyone who knows God gives us a hearing; anyone
not from God gives us none. That is how we tell the Spirit of truth
from the spirit of deception.
7 Beloved, let us love each other, for love comes from God, and all
who love are God’s children and know God. 8 Whoever does not love
has not known God, because God is love. 9 God’s love became visible
among us like this: God sent his only Son into the world so that we
could have life through him.[b] 10 Love consists in this: not that we have
loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as the sacrifice that
covers our sins.[c] 11 Dear friends, if God so loved us, we also ought to
love one another. 12 God no one has ever beheld; yet if we love one
another, God remains in us and his love has reached its goal in us.
13 By this we know that we remain in him and he in us, because he
has given us of his Spirit. 14 And we have seen and testify that the
Father has sent the Son as Savior of the world. 15 Whoever confesses
that Jesus is the Son of God, God remains in him, and he in God.[d] 16
And we ourselves have come to know the love God has for us, and we
have put our trust in it. God is love; whoever remains in love remains
in God, and God remains in that person.[e] 17 By this love is brought to
completion with us, so that we may have confidence on the day of

judgment, because as he is, so also are we in this world. 18 Fear has no
place in love; rather, love that is complete drives fear out, for fear has
to do with punishment, and one who is afraid has not yet been made
complete in love. 19 We love, because he first loved us.[f] 20 If anyone
says, "I love God," and hates his brother, he is a liar; for whoever does
not love his brother whom he has seen cannot love God whom he
has not seen.[g] 21 And this commandment we have from him: whoever
loves God must love his brother also.

Notes

- a (4:3) Refuses to confess Jesus: later manuscripts read "does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh." Some early witnesses, as reported, read "sets Jesus aside" or "dissolves Jesus" (Greek *lyei*).
- b (4:9) Unique: Greek *monogenēs*, "one and only," "only."
- c (4:10) Atoning sacrifice: Greek *hilasmos*; see 2:2.
- d (4:15) Jesus: Westcott and Hort bracket "Christ" after "Jesus."
- e (4:16) For us: literally "in us." *Remains in that person*: Westcott and Hort bracket the second "remains."
- f (4:19) We love: later manuscripts read "We love him."
- g (4:20) Cannot: some manuscripts read "how can he?"

Chapter 5

1 All who believe Jesus to be the Christ are God's offspring, and
everyone who loves the father loves his child as well. 2 By this we
know that we love the children of God, when we love God and carry
out his commandments.[a] 3 For this is the love of God, that we keep his
commandments; and his commandments are not burdensome. 4 For
everything born of God overcomes the world, and this is the victory
that has overcome the world: our faith. 5 Who conquers the world?
Only the person who believes Jesus is God's Son.[b]
6 This is the one who came by water and blood, Jesus Christ; not by
water alone, but by water and by blood. And the Spirit is the witness,
because the Spirit is truth.[c] 7 For there are three that testify:[d] 8 the
Spirit, the water and the blood; and the three are in agreement.[e] 9 If
we accept human testimony, the testimony of God is greater; for this
is the testimony of God, that he has testified concerning his Son. 10
Those who believe in God's Son carry the witness within themselves.
Those who refuse to believe God have called him a liar, since they

have not trusted the witness God has given about his Son.[f] 11 And this
is the witness: God gave us eternal life, and that life is found in his
Son. 12 To have the Son is to have life; not to have God's Son is to be
without life.
13 I have written these things to you so that you may know that you
have eternal life, you who believe in the name of the Son of God.[g]
14 We have this boldness in approaching him: whenever we ask for
anything in line with his will, he listens to us. 15 And if we know that
he hears us in whatever we ask, we know that we have the requests
we have asked of him. 16 If anyone sees his brother committing a sin
not leading to death, he shall ask, and God will give him life, for those
who sin not to death. There is sin that leads to death; I do not say
that one should pray about that. 17 Every wrong is sin, but not all sin
is deadly.
18 We know that everyone born of God does not keep on sinning, but
the one born of God guards him, and the evil one does not touch him.[h]
19 We know that we are of God, and the whole world lies in the power
of the evil one. 20 We know too that the Son of God has come and
given us insight to know the true one; and we are in the true one,
in his Son Jesus Christ. He is the true God and eternal life.[i] 21 Little
children, keep yourselves from idols.[j]

Notes

- a (5:2) Carry out: later manuscripts read "keep."
- b (5:5) Who is it: Westcott and Hort bracket a Greek particle, "and" or "but," after "who."
- c (5:6) Water and blood: perhaps Jesus' baptism and death; compare John 19:34. Some manuscripts read "water and spirit," or "water and blood and spirit."
- d (5:7) Later Latin manuscripts and a few late Greek manuscripts add, in verses 7–8, "in heaven, the Father, the Word and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one; and there are three that testify on earth." This addition, the "Johannine Comma," appears in no Greek manuscript before the 14th century except as a later marginal note, as reported in the standard editions; it entered printed Greek texts in Erasmus's third edition (1522) and so passed into the King James Version. It is not part of the text followed here.
- e (5:8) Are in agreement: literally "are into the one."
- f (5:10) In himself: some manuscripts read "in him." *Believe God*: some manuscripts read "believe the Son."

- g (5:13) Later manuscripts add “and that you may believe in the name of the Son of God.”
- h (5:18) The one born of God: that is, the Son of God. *Guards him*: many manuscripts read “guards himself.”
- i (5:20) He is the true God: “He” may refer to the Father or to Jesus Christ.
- j (5:21) Later manuscripts add “Amen.”

2 John

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 From the elder to the chosen lady and her children, whom I truly
love, and not only I but everyone who knows the truth,[a] 2 because
of the truth which lives on in us and will stay with us for all time:
3 Grace, mercy and peace will be with us from God the Father and
from Jesus Christ, the Father's Son, in truth and love.[b]
4 I was delighted to meet some of your children walking in the truth,
just as the Father commanded us.[c] 5 And now, lady, I am asking you,
not as if I were giving you some new command, but the one we have
had from the start: let us love one another. 6 Love means walking
according to his commands. This is the command you heard from
the start, and you are to walk in it. 7 Many deceivers have gone out
into the world, people who deny that Jesus Christ came as a human
being. Anyone like that is the deceiver and the antichrist.[d] 8 Look
to yourselves, that you may not throw away the fruit of our labor
but may be paid your wages in full.[e] 9 Anyone who runs ahead and
does not stay with the teaching about Christ does not have God. The
one who stays with that teaching has both the Father and the Son.[f] 10
Should anyone come to you who does not carry this teaching, do not
welcome him under your roof or bid him good day;[g] 11 for whoever
greets him shares in his evil works.
12 There is a great deal I could write to you, but I prefer not to use
paper and ink. I am hoping rather to visit you and speak with you
in person, so that our joy may be made full.[h] 13 The children of your
chosen sister greet you.[i]

Notes

- a (1:1) Elder: Greek *presbyteros*, "older man," "church leader." *The chosen lady*: probably a church and its members, personified; compare verse 13. Some take *Kyria* ("lady") as a personal name.

- b (1:3) From Jesus Christ: later manuscripts read “from the Lord Jesus Christ.”
- c (1:4) Living: literally “walking”; so in verse 6.
- d (1:7) Antichrist: Greek *antichristos*, “opponent of Christ”; compare 1 John 2:18–22.
- e (1:8) The fruit of our labor: some manuscripts read “the fruit of your labor.”
- f (1:9) Goes on ahead: later manuscripts read “transgresses.” *Remains in the teaching*: later manuscripts add “of Christ.”
- g (1:10) Under your roof: perhaps the house where the church met.
- h (1:12) In person: literally “mouth to mouth.” *Our joy*: some manuscripts read “your joy.”
- i (1:13) Later manuscripts add “Amen.”

3 John

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 The elder, to my dear Gaius, whom I love in truth.[a]
2 Dear friend, I pray that all is well with you and that you are in health,
just as it is well with your soul. 3 For I was overjoyed when brothers
came and spoke of your truth, how you are living in the truth.[b] 4 I
have no greater joy than this, to hear that my children are living in
the truth.[c]
5 Dear friend, it is a faithful thing you do in all your service to the
brothers, and to visitors from elsewhere at that. 6 They have spoken
of your love before the church. You will do well to send them on their
way in a manner worthy of God.[d] 7 It was for the Name that they went
out, taking no help from unbelievers.[e] 8 So we ought to support people
like these, so that we may become fellow workers for the truth.
9 I wrote something to the church, but Diotrephes, who likes to be first
among them, does not acknowledge us.[f] 10 So when I arrive, I will bring
up what he is doing, slandering us with wicked talk. Not satisfied
with that, he refuses to welcome the brothers himself, hinders those
who want to, and expels them from the congregation.
11 Dear friend, copy not evil but good. One who does good belongs to
God; one who does evil has never seen God. 12 Demetrius has a good
report from everyone, and from the truth itself. We add our testimony
too, and you know that our testimony is true.[g]
13 I had much to write to you, but I do not want to write it to you
with pen and ink. 14 I expect to see you before long, and then we can
speak in person.[h] 15 Peace be with you. The friends greet you. Greet
the friends by name.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Gaius*: a common Latin name, perhaps from *gaudere*, “to rejoice”; several men of this name appear in the New Testament (Acts 19:29; 20:4; Rom 16:23; 1 Cor 1:14).
- b (1:3) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, fellow believers, which includes sisters; so throughout the letter.
- c (1:4) Greater joy: some manuscripts read “greater grace.”
- d (1:6) Send them on their way: that is, provide what they need for the journey.
- e (1:7) The Name: that is, the name of Christ. *Unbelievers*: Greek *ethnikoi*, “Gentiles,” here meaning those outside the faith.
- f (1:9) *Diotrephes*: “nurtured by Zeus.” *I wrote something*: later manuscripts read “I would have written.”
- g (1:12) *Demetrius*: “belonging to Demeter,” the Greek goddess of grain.
- h (1:14) In person: literally “mouth to mouth.”

Jude

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 Jude, a slave of Jesus Christ and brother of James, to those who are
called, loved by God the Father and kept for Jesus Christ:[a] 2 Mercy,
peace and love be yours in fullest measure.
3 Dear friends, though I was fully intent on writing to you about the
salvation we hold in common, I found I must write instead to urge
you to fight hard for the faith that was entrusted once and for all to
God's holy people. 4 Some people have crept in among you unnoticed,
individuals long ago marked out for this judgment, godless persons
who twist the grace of our God into an excuse for immorality and
deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ.[b]
5 Although you already know all of this, I want to remind you that
the Lord rescued a people from Egypt, but later destroyed those who
did not trust him.[c] 6 And the angels who failed to hold on to their
own domain and deserted the home that was theirs he is holding in
everlasting bonds, beneath the gloom, until the judgment of the great
day.[d] 7 In the same way Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around
them, which like these indulged in sexual immorality and went after
other flesh, are set before us as an example in undergoing the penalty
of eternal fire.[e]
8 In just the same way these people, lost in their dreams, pollute
the flesh, set lordship aside and heap abuse on the glorious ones.[f] 9
But when Michael the archangel was contending with the devil and
arguing over the body of Moses, he did not presume to pronounce
a slanderous judgment on him, but said, "The Lord rebuke you!"[g] 10
But these people slander whatever they do not understand, and by
the things they know by instinct, like irrational animals, they are
destroyed. 11 How terrible for them! They have followed Cain's path,
abandoned themselves for gain to Balaam's error, and been destroyed

in Korah's revolt.[h] 12 These people are hidden reefs in your love feasts,
eating with you and fearing nothing, tending none but themselves;
clouds with no water, carried off by the winds; trees in late autumn
with no fruit, dead twice over, torn up by the roots;[i] 13 wild waves of
the sea, foaming up their own shameful deeds; wandering stars, for
whom the gloom of darkness has been kept forever.[j]
14 It was about these also that Enoch, the seventh from Adam, proph-
esied, saying, "See, the Lord came with his holy myriads,[k] 15 to carry
out judgment against everyone, and to convict every godless person
of all the godless acts they have performed, and of all the harsh
words that godless sinners have said against him."[l] 16 These people
are grumblers, complainers, living by their own desires; their mouths
speak arrogant words, and they flatter people for the sake of gain.
17 But you, beloved, remember what the apostles of our Lord Jesus
Christ predicted. 18 They told you, "In the last time there will be
scoffers, living by their own ungodly desires." 19 It is they who split
you apart; they live on a merely natural level, without the Spirit.[m]
20 But you, dear friends, building yourselves up on your most holy
faith and praying in the Holy Spirit, 21 keep yourselves in the love of
God, as you wait for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to
eternal life. 22 Some, who are wavering, you must pity;[n] 23 save them,
snatching them out of the fire; and others you must pity with fear,
hating even the garment stained by the flesh.
24 Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to set you
blameless and rejoicing before his glorious presence, 25 to the one and
only God our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, belong glory and
greatness, might and authority, before every age, now, and through
all the ages. Amen.[o]

Notes

- a (1:1) *Jude*: Greek *Ioudas*, from Hebrew *Yehudah* (Judah), "praised" (Gen 29:35). *James*: Greek *Iakōbos*, Jacob. *Loved*: later manuscripts read "sanctified." *Kept for Jesus Christ*: or "kept by Jesus Christ."
- b (1:4) Whose sentence was written down long ago: or "who were long ago marked out for this condemnation." *Master*: Greek *despotēs*. Later manuscripts read "the only Master, God, and our Lord Jesus Christ."

- c (1:5) The Lord: so Westcott and Hort in the text, with Sinaiticus as reported, while giving “Jesus” in the margin. “Jesus” is reported for Alexandrinus and Vaticanus and is printed in the Nestle–Aland edition; other manuscripts read “God,” and P72 is reported to read “God Christ.” *Known all this once for all*: some manuscripts place “once” with “saved.” Compare Num 14:26–35.
- d (1:6) Domain: Greek *archē*, “rule,” “position of authority.” Compare Gen 6:1–4 and 1 Enoch 10:4–6, 12.
- e (1:7) Gen 19. *Went after other flesh*: perhaps referring to the attempt on the angels in Gen 19:4–11.
- f (1:8) Glorious ones: Greek *doxai*, “glories,” probably angelic beings.
- g (1:9) *Michael*: “who is like God?” (compare Dan 10:13; 12:1). The story is reported by early writers from the *Assumption of Moses*, a Jewish work of which only part survives. *The Lord rebuke you*: compare Zech 3:2, where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.
- h (1:11) *Cain*: Gen 4:1–16. *Balaam*: Num 22–24; 31:16. *Korah*: “bald”; Num 16:1–35.
- i (1:12) Hidden reefs: or “stains” (Greek *spilades*). *Love feasts*: Greek *agapai*, communal meals of the early church.
- j (1:13) Compare Isa 57:20. *Wandering stars*: compare 1 Enoch 18:13–16; 21:1–6.
- k (1:14) *Enoch*: perhaps “dedicated” (Gen 5:18–24). *Seventh from Adam*: counting Adam as the first (Gen 5:1–24; compare 1 Enoch 60:8). The quotation in verses 14–15 is from 1 Enoch 1:9, a Jewish work preserved complete only in Ethiopic, with Greek and Aramaic fragments. *Myriads*: tens of thousands.
- l (1:15) To convict all the ungodly: some manuscripts read “to convict every soul.”
- m (1:19) Merely natural: Greek *psychikoi*, “natural,” “unspiritual.”
- n (1:22) Verses 22–23 are textually uncertain. Westcott and Hort print a text that names two groups, and they suspected an early corruption. Other manuscripts name three groups, with wording to the effect of “Have mercy on some who waver; rescue others by pulling them from the fire; and show mercy mixed with fear to still others.” Still others read “Rebuke some who waver.”
- o (1:25) Through Jesus Christ our Lord: later manuscripts omit these words. *Before every age*: later manuscripts omit these words.

Revelation

New Testament

Chapter 1

1 The unveiling of Jesus Christ, which God gave him in order to
show his slaves what must happen before long. Jesus signified it by
dispatching his angel to his slave John,[a] 2 He has testified to God's
word and to what Jesus Christ attested, all that he saw. 3 Blessed is
the person who reads this prophecy aloud, and blessed are the ones
who listen to it and hold fast to the things written here, because the
appointed time is close.[b]
4 John, to the seven churches in Asia: favor and peace to you from
him who is, and was, and is on his way, and from the seven spirits
that stand before his throne,[c]
5 and from Jesus Christ, the witness who keeps faith, first of the dead
to be born to life, ruler over earth's kings. ¶To him who loves us, who
by his own blood has freed us from our sins,[d]
6 and made us a royal house, priests for God, his Father. To him belong
glory and dominion through the ages of ages. Amen.[e]
7 Behold, he comes among the clouds,
and every eye will look on him,
even the ones who stabbed him,
and all the peoples of the land will beat their breasts for him.
Yes, truly. Amen.[f]
8 "I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, who is, and was,
and is on his way, the Almighty.[g]
9 I am John, your brother and your companion in the tribulation,
the kingdom, and the perseverance that belong to Jesus. I came to
be on the island named Patmos on account of God's word and the
witness of Jesus.[h] 10 In the Spirit I came to be, on the Lord's day, and
behind me I heard a great voice, resounding like a trumpet,[i] 11 and
it said, "Whatever you see, write it in a scroll and transmit it to the

seven churches—Ephesus and Smyrna and Pergamum and Thyatira and Sardis and Philadelphia and Laodicea."[j]

12 So I wheeled around to look at the voice that was speaking to me. On wheeling, I observed seven lampstands made of gold, 13 and in the midst of the lampstands a figure like a son of man, wearing a garment that reached to his feet and a golden band across his breast.[k] 14 His head and hair shone with a whiteness like wool or fresh snow, and his eyes blazed like fire;[l] 15 his feet resembled bronze glowing hot in a kiln, and his voice rang out like a roar of many waters.[m] 16 His right hand held seven stars. A sharp sword with two edges projected from his mouth. His face shone as the sun does at midday.

17 On seeing him, I fell at his feet like one who was dead. Then he rested his right hand upon me, saying, "Fear not. I am the first and the last,[n] 18 as well as the one who lives. I died, and see, I am alive for all the ages, and I hold the keys of Death and of Hades.[o] 19 So write what you have seen, both what is now and what is to happen after this. 20 This is the secret of the seven stars that you saw at my right hand, and of the seven golden lampstands: the seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are the seven churches themselves.[p]

Notes

- a (1:1) Revelation: Greek *apokalypsis*, "unveiling." *Jesus*: Greek form of the Hebrew *Yeshuaʿ*, "Yahweh saves." *John*: from the Hebrew *Yoḥanan*, "Yahweh is gracious." *Slaves*: Greek *douloi*, "slaves," "servants."
- b (1:3) Happy: or "blessed"; so in the other six beatitudes of the book (22:14, 22:7, 20:6, 19:9, 16:15 and 14:13). *Reads aloud*: that is, in the assembly.
- c (1:4) Asia: the Roman province in the west of what is now Turkey. *The one who is*: compare Exod 3:14 in the Greek Old Testament, where God names himself. *Seven spirits*: perhaps the Holy Spirit in his fullness (compare Isa 11:2; Zech 4:2–10), or seven angelic beings.
- d (1:5) Ps 89:27, 37 (Greek Old Testament 88:28, 38). *Set us free*: later manuscripts read "washed." *Our sins*: Westcott and Hort bracket "our."
- e (1:6) Exod 19:6. *Forever and ever*: literally "to the ages of the ages"; so throughout.
- f (1:7) Dan 7:13; Zech 12:10–14.
- g (1:8) Alpha … Omega: the opening and closing letters of the Greek alphabet; compare 21:6; 22:13. Later manuscripts add "the beginning and the end." *The Lord God … the Almighty*: in the Greek Old Testament *kyrios ho theos ho pan-

tokratōr* renders Hebrew *Yahweh ʾElohe tsevaʾot*, “Yahweh, God of Armies” (for example Amos 3:13; 4:13).

- h (1:9) Brother: Greek *adelphos*; the plural *adelphoi* in this book includes sisters. *Patmos*: a small Aegean island lying roughly 37 miles (60 km) southwest of Miletus.
- i (1:10) In the Spirit: or “in spirit,” that is, in a prophetic trance. *The Lord’s day*: Greek *kyriakē hēmera*, probably Sunday.
- j (1:11) The seven cities lie on a circular road in the province of Asia. *Ephesus*: perhaps “desirable.” *Smyrna*: “myrrh.” *Pergamum*: perhaps “citadel.” *Thyatira*: of uncertain meaning. *Sardis*: of uncertain meaning. *Philadelphia*: “brotherly love,” named after King Attalus II Philadelphus. *Laodicea*: “justice of the people,” named after Laodice, a Seleucid queen. Later manuscripts add at the start of the verse “I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last.”
- k (1:13) Son of man: compare Dan 7:13; 10:5–6.
- l (1:14) Compare Dan 7:9.
- m (1:15) Fine bronze: Greek *chalkolibanon*, a word not found before this book, apparently a fine alloy of bronze. Compare Ezek 1:24; 43:2.
- n (1:17) Compare Isa 44:6; 48:12.
- o (1:18) Hades: the Greek name for the realm of the dead. Later manuscripts add “Amen.”
- p (1:20) Angels: or “messengers”; the Greek word *angelos* means both.

Chapter 2

1 “To the angel of the church in Ephesus, write: ¶‘These are the words
of him who grips the seven stars in his right hand and walks about
among the seven golden lampstands: 2 I know your works—how hard
you labor and how you persevere—and that you cannot endure bad
people. You tested those who claim to be apostles though they are not,
and you discovered that they were liars. 3 You are enduring, and for
my name’s sake you have borne hardships without growing weary. 4
But I hold this against you, that you have left the love you had at first.
5 Call to mind, then, the height you fell from; turn back, and act as
you did in the beginning. Otherwise I am coming to you, and unless
you turn back I will take your lampstand away from where it stands.
6 But you have this to your credit: you detest what the Nicolaitans do,
as I do too.[a] 7 Anyone who has an ear, let him pay attention to the
Spirit’s message for the churches. I will give the conqueror a share of
the tree of life, which grows in the paradise of God.’[b]

8 “To the angel of the Smyrna church write: ¶‘Thus speaks the first
and the last, who became dead and came alive again: 9 I am aware of
your tribulation and poverty—yet you are rich—and of the blasphemy
against you by people claiming to be Jews who are not, but are Satan’s
synagogue.[c] 10 Do not be afraid of what you will soon suffer. Notice:
the devil is going to put some of you in prison as a test, and you will
endure tribulation for ten days. Prove faithful to the point of dying,
and I will present you with the crown of life.[d] 11 Anyone who has an
ear, let him pay attention to the Spirit’s message for the churches.
The one who conquers will suffer no injury from the second death.’
12 “To the angel of the church in Pergamum, write: ¶‘These are the
words of him who holds the sharp, double-edged sword: 13 I am aware
of where you dwell, where Satan’s throne stands. You keep a firm hold
on my name, and you never abandoned your faith in me, even during
the days when Antipas, my faithful witness, was killed in your midst,
where Satan dwells.[e] 14 But a few matters count against you. There are
people with you who maintain the doctrine of Balaam, who taught
Balak to lay a trap before the people of Israel: to eat idol sacrifices
and to fornicate.[f] 15 In the same way you also have some who adhere
to the teaching of the Nicolaitans. 16 Repent, then. If not, I am coming
against you swiftly, and I will fight them with the sword of my mouth.
17 Anyone who has an ear, let him pay attention to the Spirit’s message
for the churches. I will give the conqueror a portion of the concealed
manna. I will give him a white pebble as well, and engraved on the
pebble is a new name, which nobody recognizes except its recipient.’[g]
18 “To the angel of the Thyatira church write: ¶‘Thus speaks the Son of
God, the one with eyes like a blaze of fire and with feet like burnished
bronze:[h] 19 I am aware of your works—your love, faith, ministry, and
perseverance—and that your recent works exceed the earlier ones. 20
Yet this is my complaint against you: you put up with Jezebel, that
woman who declares herself a prophetess; she instructs my slaves
and misleads them into fornicating and eating idol sacrifices.[i] 21 Time
to repent was given to her, but she is unwilling to turn back from
her fornication. 22 Watch: I will cast her on a bed, and her fellow
adulterers into severe tribulation, if they do not repent of her deeds.[j]

23 Her children I will strike with death, and every church will come
to know that I am he who probes the inner self and the heart, and
that I will repay each one of you as your deeds deserve.[k] 24 But to the
remaining ones in Thyatira—as many as lack this teaching, such as
have not known the so-called "deep things of Satan"—I tell you: I am
not loading any other burden on you;[l] 25 just keep a firm grip on what
you have until I arrive. 26 To the conqueror, who guards my works
right to the end, I will grant authority over the nations, 27 and he will
shepherd them with an iron rod, as clay vessels are smashed to pieces,
just as I too have received it from my Father;[m] 28 and I will hand him
the morning star. 29 Anyone who has an ear, let him pay attention to
the Spirit's message for the churches.'

Notes

- a (2:6) Nicolaitans: a group otherwise known only from later reports; the name may mean "conqueror of the people." Compare verse 15.
- b (2:7) Gen 2:9; 3:22. *Paradise*: a Persian word for a walled garden or park, used in the Greek Old Testament for the garden of Eden.
- c (2:9) Satan: Hebrew *satan*, "adversary," "accuser." Later manuscripts add "your works" after "I know."
- d (2:10) Devil: Greek *diabolos*, "slanderer."
- e (2:13) Antipas: "in place of the father," a shortened form of Antipater; nothing more is known of him. *My faithful one*: Westcott and Hort bracket the second "my." *Satan's throne*: perhaps the great altar of Zeus, the temple of Augustus, or the city as a center of the imperial cult.
- f (2:14) Num 25:1–3; 31:16. *Balaam*: perhaps "devourer." *Balak*: "devastator." *Israel*: "God strives" or "he strives with God" (Gen 32:28).
- g (2:17) Manna: Exod 16:31–35. *Pebble*: Greek *psēphos*, a small smooth stone. Its meaning here is uncertain; white pebbles were used in antiquity as tokens of acquittal, admission or membership.
- h (2:18) Eyes: Westcott and Hort bracket "his" before "eyes."
- i (2:20) Jezebel: the name of King Ahab's wife (1 Kgs 16:31; 21:25–26; 2 Kgs 9:22), used here of a prophetess in Thyatira; perhaps "where is the prince?" *The woman*: many manuscripts read "your wife."
- j (2:22) Her works: some manuscripts read "their works."
- k (2:23) Strike with death: literally "kill with death," perhaps "with plague." *Minds*: literally "kidneys," regarded as the seat of the feelings. Compare Jer 17:10.
- l (2:24) Compare Acts 15:28.
- m (2:27) Ps 2:8–9 in the Greek Old Testament. *Shepherd*: or "rule."

Chapter 3

1 “To the angel of the Sardis church write: ¶‘Thus speaks he who
possesses the seven spirits of God and the seven stars: I am aware of
your works—that you bear a name saying you live, though you are
dead. 2 Wake up! Shore up what is left, for it is on the point of dying.
I have not found what you have done to be complete before my God.
3 Call to mind, therefore, what you received and heard; guard it, and
repent. If you do not rouse yourself, I will arrive like a thief, and you
will not learn at which hour I will reach you. 4 Still, there are a few
people in Sardis whose clothing is unstained; they will walk at my
side dressed in white, for they deserve it.[a] 5 Thus will the conqueror
be clothed in white clothes; and his name I will never blot out of the
book of life, but I will confess his name before my Father and before
his angels. 6 Anyone who has an ear, let him pay attention to the
Spirit’s message for the churches.’
7 “To the angel of the Philadelphia church write: ¶‘Thus speaks the
holy one, the genuine one, who holds the key of David; what he
opens, none will close, and what he closes, none opens:[b] 8 I am aware
of your works. Observe: I have placed before you a doorway, opened,
that nobody has power to close. You possess little strength; still, you
kept my word and did not deny my name. 9 Observe, I am handing
over some from Satan’s synagogue, who call themselves Jews and are
not, but are liars. I will cause them to arrive and kneel at your feet,
and to learn that I have loved you.[c] 10 Since you guarded my message
of patient endurance, I in turn will guard you from the hour of testing
that is about to come upon the entire inhabited world, to try the
people living on earth. 11 I am coming quickly. Keep a firm grip on
what you have, so that nobody robs you of your crown. 12 The victor I
will make a pillar in the temple of my God, and he will go out from it
no more. I will write on him the name of my God, and the name of the
city of my God—the new Jerusalem that comes down out of heaven
from my God—and also my own new name.[d] 13 Anyone who has an
ear, let him pay attention to the Spirit’s message for the churches.’
14 “To the angel of the Laodicea church write: ¶‘Thus speaks the
Amen, the reliable and genuine witness, the source of God’s creation:[e]

15 I am aware of your works, that you are not cold and not hot. I would
prefer you to be either cold or hot. 16 Thus, because you are warm and
neither hot nor cold, I intend to spit you out of my mouth.[f] 17 You keep
saying, "I am rich; I have grown wealthy; there is nothing I lack." You
do not realize that it is you who are miserable and pitiful, poor and
blind and naked.[g] 18 I advise you to acquire from me gold fired and
purified, to make you wealthy; also white garments for you to wear,
so that your disgraceful nudity is concealed; and ointment to put on
your eyes, that you may see.[h] 19 I correct and train everyone I love.
Be zealous, then, and change your ways.[i] 20 Look at me, standing at
the door and knocking! Should anyone hear my voice and open the
door, I will enter and dine with that person, and he with me. 21 To the
one who prevails I will grant a place beside me on my throne, as I
too prevailed and sat down with my Father on his throne. 22 Anyone
who has an ear, let him pay attention to the Spirit's message for the
churches.'"

Notes

- a (3:4) People: literally "names."
- b (3:7) Isa 22:22. *David*: "beloved."
- c (3:9) Compare Isa 45:14; 49:23; 60:14; 43:4.
- d (3:12) Jerusalem: perhaps "foundation of peace."
- e (3:14) Amen: a Hebrew word meaning "firm," "true"; compare Isa 65:16. *Beginning*: or "origin," "ruler." *True*: Westcott and Hort bracket the article before this word.
- f (3:16) Laodicea's water was piped in from a distance and arrived tepid, unlike the hot springs of nearby Hierapolis and the cold water of Colossae.
- g (3:17) Compare Hos 12:8.
- h (3:18) Laodicea was a banking center, known for its black wool and for a medical school associated with an eye remedy.
- i (3:19) Compare Prov 3:12.

Chapter 4

1 After this I looked, and an open door appeared in heaven. The first
voice, the one I had heard like a trumpet speaking with me, now said,
"Climb up here, and I will let you see what must occur after these
events."

2 At once I was in the Spirit. There in heaven stood a throne, with
someone seated on the throne.
3 The one seated there looked like jasper and carnelian in appearance,
and around the throne was a rainbow resembling an emerald.[a]
4 Encircling the throne stood twenty-four other thrones, and on them
sat twenty-four elders dressed in white, wearing crowns of gold.
5 Out of the throne burst lightning, rumbling and thunder, while in
front of it seven fiery torches were burning, the seven spirits of God;[b]
6 and in front of the throne lay what seemed a glass sea like crystal.
¶In the center, around the throne, stood four living beings with eyes
covering them, front and back.[c]
7 The first being resembled a lion, the second a young bull, the
third had a human-looking face, and the fourth resembled an eagle
in flight.[d]
8 Each of the four living creatures has six wings and is covered with
eyes, round about and underneath, and without rest, by day or by
night, they keep saying,

"Holy, holy, holy,
Lord God Almighty,
who was and who is and who is coming!"[e]

9 Whenever the living beings render glory, honor, and thanks to the
occupant of the throne, who lives to the ages of ages,
10 the twenty-four elders will prostrate themselves in front of the
occupant of the throne and will worship the one who lives to the ages
of ages. They will throw their crowns before the throne and say:
11 "Deserving are you, our Lord and our God,
of taking the glory, the honor, and the power;
for you made all things,
and it is by your desire that they existed and were created."[f]

Notes

- a (4:3) Jasper: in antiquity the name covered several precious stones, perhaps here a clear, bright stone (compare 21:11). *Carnelian*: Greek *sardion*, a red stone named after Sardis.
- b (4:5) Rumbling: literally "voices." Compare Exod 19:16.

- c (4:6) In the center, around the throne: the meaning of the Greek is uncertain; perhaps "in the middle of each side of the throne." Compare Ezek 1:5–25; 10:12.
- d (4:7) Compare Ezek 1:10.
- e (4:8) Isa 6:2–3, where the Hebrew has "Yahweh of Armies."
- f (4:11) Our Lord and God: a title also claimed by the emperor Domitian, according to Suetonius.

Chapter 5

1 In the right hand of him who sat on the throne I then saw a scroll
with writing inside and on the reverse, sealed up with seven seals.[a]
2 I also saw a powerful angel announcing in a booming voice, "Who
deserves to open the scroll and undo its seals?" 3 Yet nobody in the
heavens, nor on the land, nor beneath the ground had the ability to
unroll the scroll or peer into it. 4 I began to weep bitterly, because no
one had been found who deserved to open the scroll or look inside
it.[b] 5 But one of the elders told me, "Stop weeping. See, the lion from
Judah's tribe, David's root, has won the victory; he can open the scroll
with its seven seals."[c]
6 Then, in the very center—with the throne and its four living crea-
tures on one side and the elders on the other—I saw a Lamb standing,
bearing the marks of slaughter. He had seven horns and seven eyes,
and these are the seven spirits of God, commissioned to go out over
all the earth.[d]
7 The Lamb came and took the scroll out of the right hand of him who
sat on the throne.
8 As he took the scroll, the four living creatures and the twenty-four
elders prostrated themselves before the Lamb. Every one of them held
a harp and golden bowls full of incense—the prayers of God's holy
people.
9 They sing a new song:

"You deserve to take the scroll
and open its seals,
since you were slaughtered, and with your blood you bought for God
people out of every tribe, language, nation, and people,[e]

10 and you made them into a kingdom, priests serving our God,
and they reign over the earth."[f]
11 And I looked and heard a sound: many angels in a ring around
the throne, around the living creatures, and around the elders. Their
number was myriads upon myriads and thousands upon thousands,[g]
12 calling out in a great voice,
"The slaughtered Lamb deserves
to receive might and wealth, wisdom and strength,
honor and glory and praise!"
13 I heard, too, every creature that is in heaven, on the land, beneath
the ground, and on the sea—everything in them—saying,
"Praise, honor, glory, and might
belong to him who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb,
for ever and ever!"[h]
14 And the four living creatures said, "Amen!" And the elders fell down
and worshiped.[i]

Notes

- a (5:1) Compare Ezek 2:9–10; Isa 29:11.
- b (5:4) I: Westcott and Hort bracket the emphatic pronoun.
- c (5:5) Gen 49:9–10; Isa 11:1, 10. *Judah*: "praised" (Gen 29:35).
- d (5:6) Seven spirits: Westcott and Hort bracket "seven." Compare Isa 53:7; Zech 4:10.
- e (5:9) Purchased for God: some manuscripts read "purchased us for God," and Alexandrinus as reported lacks "for God." *Those of every tribe*: literally "from every tribe."
- f (5:10) They reign: some manuscripts read "they will reign." Later manuscripts read "made us … and we will reign."
- g (5:11) Myriads of myriads: literally "ten thousands of ten thousands"; compare Dan 7:10.
- h (5:13) On the sea: Westcott and Hort bracket a Greek verb after these words.
- i (5:14) Later manuscripts add "twenty-four" before "elders" and "him who lives forever and ever" after "worshiped."

Chapter 6

1 Then I watched as the Lamb opened one of the seven seals, and I
heard one of the four living creatures speak in a thunderous voice:
"Come!"[a] 2 And I looked: a white horse, and its rider holding a bow!

A crown was given him, and he rode forth as a conqueror, bent on conquest.
3 When he opened the second seal, I heard the second living creature
say, "Come!" 4 Then another horse came out, red as fire, and its rider
was given leave to take away peace from the earth and make people
butcher one another; a huge sword was handed to him.[b]
5 When the third seal was opened by the Lamb, I heard the third living
creature cry, "Come!" And what I saw was a black horse, and the rider
on it held a pair of balances in his hand. 6 And I heard what sounded
like a voice amid the four living beings, saying, "Wheat is a quart
for a day's wage, and barley is three quarts for a day's wage; do not
injure the oil and wine."[c]
7 When he opened the fourth seal, I heard the voice of the fourth living
creature saying, "Come!" 8 And there before me was a pale green
horse, and the name of its rider was Death, and Hades came behind
him. Authority was given to them over one quarter of the earth, to
kill with the sword, with famine, with deadly disease, and through
the wild beasts of the earth.[d]
9 When he opened the fifth seal, I saw beneath the altar the souls of
people who had been put to death because of God's word and because
of the witness they maintained. 10 They shouted in a great voice:
"Holy and true Master, how long until you give judgment and take
vengeance for our blood upon the inhabitants of the earth?"[e] 11 Each
of them received a white robe, and word came to them to take rest for
a little time yet, until the count was complete of their fellow slaves
and their brothers, those soon to be put to death, as they had been.[f]
12 Then he opened the sixth seal, and I watched. A great earthquake
struck, the sun turned black like a sack woven of hair, and the full
moon turned red as blood,[g] 13 Down to the earth fell the stars of
heaven, like unripe figs flung from a fig tree when a strong wind
shakes it.[h] 14 The sky was torn away like a scroll being rolled up, and
every mountain and island was shifted from its place. 15 Earth's kings,
its great men and its commanders, the wealthy and the mighty, every
slave and every free person hid in caves and among mountain crags,[i]
16 and they call to the mountains and to the rocks: "Fall upon us and

hide us from the face of the one seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb,[j] 17 for the great day of their anger has arrived, and who can remain standing?"[k]

Notes

- a (6:1) Come: later manuscripts read "Come and see"; so also in verses 3, 5 and 7.
- b (6:4) Was given leave: Westcott and Hort bracket "to him" here and "from" before "the earth."
- c (6:6) Quart: Greek *choinix*, a dry measure of about 1 liter (just over a quart), roughly one person's daily ration of grain. *A day's wage*: Greek *dēnarion*, a Roman silver coin, the usual daily wage of a laborer (Matt 20:2). The prices are many times the normal rate, signifying famine.
- d (6:8) The color of a corpse: Greek *chlōros*, "pale green." *Pestilence*: literally "death." Compare Ezek 14:21. Westcott and Hort bracket "it" after "its rider" and the article before "Death."
- e (6:10) Master: Greek *despotēs*.
- f (6:11) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters. *Until the number was complete*: or "until their fellow slaves and brothers had completed their course."
- g (6:12) Compare Joel 2:10, 31; Isa 50:3.
- h (6:13) Compare Isa 34:4.
- i (6:15) Commanders: Greek *chiliarchoi*, "commanders of a thousand," military tribunes.
- j (6:16) Hos 10:8; compare Luke 23:30.
- k (6:17) Their wrath: some manuscripts read "his wrath." Compare Joel 2:11; Mal 3:2.

Chapter 7

1 After this I saw four angels standing on the earth's four corners, holding back its four winds so that no wind would blow upon land, upon sea, or upon any tree. 2 And I saw a different angel ascending from the sunrise, carrying the living God's seal; he called out in a great voice to the four angels who had received permission to injure earth and sea, 3 "Harm neither the earth nor the sea nor the trees, until we have sealed the foreheads of our God's slaves."[a] 4 And I heard how many were sealed: one hundred forty-four thousand, sealed out of every tribe of Israel's descendants: 5 Out of Judah's tribe twelve thousand sealed; out of Reuben's, twelve thousand; out of Gad's, twelve thousand;[b] 6 out of Asher's, twelve thousand; out of Naphtali's, twelve thousand; out of Manasseh's, twelve thousand;[c] 7

out of Simeon's, twelve thousand; out of Levi's, twelve thousand; out of Issachar's, twelve thousand;[d] [8] out of Zebulun's, twelve thousand; out of Joseph's, twelve thousand; out of Benjamin's, twelve thousand sealed.[e]

[9] After this I looked, and behold, a vast crowd that nobody could count, drawn from every nation, tribe, people, and language, stood in front of the throne and also before the Lamb. They were dressed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands,

[10] And with a great shout they cry,

"Salvation is the gift of our God,
who sits upon the throne,
and of the Lamb!"

[11] All the angels were standing in a circle about the throne, the elders and the four living creatures; and before the throne they fell face down and worshiped God,

[12] and said,

"Amen! Praise and glory and wisdom,
thanks and honor,
might and strength,
belong to our God for ever and ever! Amen."[f]

[13] And one of the elders began to question me: "These who are wearing the white robes—who are they, and from where did they come?"

[14] I replied, "My lord, you know." He answered me, "These are the ones who are coming out of the great affliction. They have washed their robes and made them white in the Lamb's blood.[g]

[15] For this reason they are before God's throne
and serve him by day and by night in his sanctuary;
the one seated on the throne will spread a shelter over them.[h]

[16] Never again will they be hungry, never again thirsty;
no sun will beat down on them,
no burning heat,[i]

[17] for the Lamb who is at the throne's center will be their shepherd;
he will guide them to fountains of life-giving water,
and every tear God will wipe from their eyes."[j]

Notes

- a (7:3) Compare Ezek 9:4.
- b (7:5) Reuben: "see, a son" (Gen 29:32). *Gad*: "fortune" (Gen 30:11). The list differs from the Old Testament lists of the tribes: Dan is missing, and Joseph and his son Manasseh both appear.
- c (7:6) *Asher*: "happy" (Gen 30:13). *Naphtali*: "my wrestling" (Gen 30:8). *Manasseh*: "making to forget" (Gen 41:51).
- d (7:7) *Simeon*: "he has heard" (Gen 29:33). *Levi*: "joined" (Gen 29:34). *Issachar*: "there is reward" (Gen 30:18).
- e (7:8) *Zebulun*: "honor" or "dwelling" (Gen 30:20). *Joseph*: "may he add" (Gen 30:24). *Benjamin*: "son of the right hand" (Gen 35:18).
- f (7:12) Amen: Westcott and Hort bracket the final "Amen."
- g (7:14) Compare Dan 12:1.
- h (7:15) Spread his tent over them: that is, shelter them with his presence.
- i (7:16) Isa 49:10.
- j (7:17) Ps 23:1–2; Isa 25:8. *Life-giving water*: literally "waters of life."

Chapter 8

1 When he opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for
about half an hour.[a]
2 And I saw the seven angels who stand before God, and seven
trumpets were given to them. 3 And another angel came and stood
by the altar with a gold incense pan. He was given a great amount of
incense, in order to present it with the prayers of all the holy people
at the golden altar before the throne. 4 And the smoke of the incense
rose from the angel's hand before God, along with the prayers of the
holy people. 5 Then the angel picked up the censer, put into it some
fire from the altar, and cast it down upon the land. Thunder rumbled,
voices sounded, lightning flashed, and the ground shook.[b]
6 The seven angels with the seven trumpets now got ready to blow. 7
The first angel sounded his trumpet; hail and fire mingled with blood
came down and was flung to the earth. One third of the earth burned
up, one third of the trees burned up, and every blade of green grass
burned up.[c] 8 The second angel sounded his trumpet, and what looked
like a great burning mountain was thrown into the sea; one third of
the sea became blood, 9 one third of the creatures in the sea that had
life died, and one third of the ships were destroyed. 10 The third angel
sounded, and down from heaven fell a huge star, flaming like a torch;

it fell upon a third of the rivers and upon the springs. 11 The star is called Wormwood. A third of the water turned to wormwood, and many people died of the water, since it had turned bitter.[d] 12 The fourth angel sounded his trumpet. One third of the sun was struck, and one third of the moon, and one third of the stars, so that one third of them was darkened and the day lost one third of its light, and the night likewise.

13 Then, as I looked, I heard an eagle flying in midheaven call out in a great voice: "Woe! Woe! Woe to the earth's inhabitants, on account of the other trumpet blasts about to be sounded by the three remaining angels!"[e]

Notes

- a (8:1) About half an hour: Greek *hōs hēmiōrion*, "about a half-hour." The ancient hour was a twelfth of the daylight or of the night, and so varied in length with the season.
- b (8:5) Compare Ezek 10:2. *Censer*: a pan for carrying burning coals and incense.
- c (8:7) Compare Exod 9:23–25. *A third of the earth was burned up*: later manuscripts omit these words.
- d (8:11) Wormwood: a plant with a very bitter taste (Greek *apsinthos*); compare Jer 9:15.
- e (8:13) Eagle: later manuscripts read "angel."

Chapter 9

1 The fifth angel sounded his trumpet, and I saw a star that had dropped from heaven to the earth. To the star was given the key of the pit of the abyss.[a] 2 It unlocked the shaft of the abyss, and up from the shaft billowed smoke like smoke from a huge furnace, and the sun and the air grew dark with the smoke from the shaft. 3 Locusts came down out of the smoke to the earth, and they were granted the kind of power that scorpions of the earth have.[b] 4 They were told to do no damage to the grass of the earth, or to any green plant or tree, but only to those people who lack God's seal on their foreheads. 5 They were allowed not to kill them but to torment them five months, and their torment is like the torment of a scorpion when it strikes a person.[c] 6 In those days people will search for death but will not discover it; they will yearn to die, and death will flee from them. 7 In

appearance the locusts resembled horses made ready for war. They wore on their heads something like golden crowns, and they had faces like human faces.[d] 8 They had hair like women's hair, and their teeth were like those of lions.[e] 9 Their chests were like breastplates of iron, and the sound of their wings was like the thunder of many chariots with horses rushing into war. 10 Their tails are like those of scorpions, with stings, and the power to injure people for five months lies in their tails. 11 They have a king over them, the angel of the abyss; his name in Hebrew is Abaddon, but in Greek he has the name Apollyon.[f]
12 The first woe is past; two more woes are still to come after this.
13 The sixth angel sounded his trumpet, and I heard one voice coming from the corners of the golden altar that is in God's presence,[g] 14 It said to the sixth angel, the trumpet holder: "Release the four angels who are held bound at the great river, the Euphrates."[h] 15 And the four angels were let loose, who stood ready for that precise hour and day and month and year, to kill one third of humanity.[i] 16 The number of the mounted troops was two hundred million; I heard what their number was.[j] 17 This is how the horses and their riders looked in my vision: the riders wore breastplates of fiery red, deep blue, and brimstone yellow. The horses had heads like lions' heads, and fire, smoke, and brimstone streamed from their mouths.[k] 18 These three plagues, the fire and smoke and sulfur pouring from the horses' mouths, killed a third of humankind. 19 The horses' power lies in their mouths and in their tails as well, for their tails look like serpents and have heads, and by means of them they inflict injury.
20 The people who remained, who had not been killed in these plagues, nevertheless did not repent of what their hands had made, nor stop worshiping the demons and the golden, silver, bronze, stone and wooden idols, which have no power to see, to hear or to walk.[l] 21 Nor did they turn away from their murders, their sorceries, their sexual immorality or their thefts.[m]

Notes

- a (9:1) Abyss: Greek *abyssos*, "bottomless," the deep underworld prison of hostile spirits.
- b (9:3) Compare Exod 10:12–15; Joel 1–2.

- c (9:5) Five months: roughly the life span of a locust.
- d (9:7) Compare Joel 2:4–5.
- e (9:8) Compare Joel 1:6.
- f (9:11) Abaddon: Hebrew for “destruction,” a name for the realm of the dead (Job 26:6; Prov 15:11). *Apollyon*: Greek for “destroyer,” perhaps also a play on the name of the god Apollo.
- g (9:13) Four horns: Westcott and Hort read only “the horns”; many manuscripts add “four.”
- h (9:14) Euphrates: the great river of Mesopotamia, the eastern frontier of the Roman world; the name perhaps means “fruitful.”
- i (9:15) That hour: not a time of day but the appointed moment; Greek *eis tēn hōran*, “for the hour.” The single article governs all four nouns, pointing to one fixed time.
- j (9:16) Two hundred million: Greek *dismyriades myriadōn*, “twice ten thousand times ten thousand.”
- k (9:17) Dark blue: Greek *hyakinthinos*, the color of the hyacinth, a deep blue or violet. *Sulfur*: Greek *theion*, traditionally “brimstone.”
- l (9:20) Compare Dan 5:23; Ps 135:15–17; 115:4–7.
- m (9:21) Sorceries: Greek *pharmaka*, “drugs,” “potions,” “spells.”

Chapter 10

1 Then I saw another mighty angel descending from heaven. A cloud
was wrapped around him, a rainbow crowned his head, his face was
like the sun, and his legs were like pillars of fire.[a] 2 He had a small
scroll in his hand, unrolled. Then he placed his right foot on the sea
and his left on the land, 3 and cried out with a great voice, as a lion
roars. And when he cried out, the seven thunders uttered their voices.
4 When the seven thunders spoke, I was on the point of writing, but
I heard a voice out of heaven saying, “Put a seal on what the seven
thunders said; do not write it down.”[b] 5 Then the angel I had seen
standing upon the sea and upon the land lifted up his right hand to
heaven 6 and took an oath by the One who lives to the ages of the ages,
the maker of heaven and all it holds, of the earth and all it holds, and
of the sea and all it holds: “Time is up; there will be no more waiting.[c]
7 but in the days of the seventh angel’s voice, when he is about to
sound his trumpet, the hidden purpose of God will be completed, just
as he announced to his slaves the prophets.”[d]

8 The voice I had heard out of heaven was speaking to me once more,
and it said, "Go and take the scroll that lies unrolled on the hand of
the angel who is standing on the sea and on the land." 9 And I went to
that angel and asked him for the little scroll. "Here, take it and eat it,"
he replied. "It will embitter your belly, yet in your mouth it will be as
sweet as honey."[e] 10 I took the small scroll from the angel's hand and
ate it up. In my mouth it tasted sweet as honey, yet once I had eaten it,
my stomach turned bitter. 11 Then I was told, "Once more you have to
prophesy, concerning many peoples, nations, languages and kings."[f]

Notes

- a (10:1) Legs: literally "feet."
- b (10:4) Compare Dan 8:26; 12:4, 9.
- c (10:6) Dan 12:7; compare Deut 32:40. *Of the sea and all it holds*: Westcott and Hort bracket these words. *No more waiting*: literally "time will no longer be."
- d (10:7) Compare Amos 3:7.
- e (10:9) Ezek 2:8–3:3.
- f (10:11) Concerning: or "against."

Chapter 11

1 I was given a measuring rod like a staff, and told, "Rise, and measure
God's temple and the altar, and count the people who worship in it.[a]
2 But the outer court of the temple, leave it out and do not measure
it, since it was given over to the nations, who will trample down the
holy city for forty-two months.[b] 3 I will empower my two witnesses,
and clothed in sackcloth they will prophesy during one thousand two
hundred sixty days."[c] 4 These are the two olive trees and the two lamp-
stands that stand before the Lord of the earth.[d] 5 Should any enemy try
to injure them, flames stream out of their mouths and devour the foes;
in just that way every would-be attacker is doomed to die.[e] 6 These
two possess the power to close up heaven, so that during the span of
their prophesying no showers come down; they also command the
waters, changing them to blood, and can afflict the land with plagues
of every sort as often as they like.[f] 7 When their witnessing is finished,
the beast coming up from the bottomless pit will battle them, defeat
them, and put them to death.[g] 8 And their corpses will lie in the broad
street of the great city, which is called, in a spiritual sense, Sodom and

Egypt, where their Lord also was crucified.[h] 9 For three and a half days
people from every people, tribe, language and nation gaze at their
corpses and refuse to let them be laid in a tomb. 10 Those who live on
the earth gloat over them and celebrate and exchange gifts, because
these two prophets had tormented the inhabitants of the earth. 11 After
three and a half days, however, life-giving breath from God entered
them. They rose upright, and terror gripped the people looking on.[i] 12
And they heard a mighty voice out of heaven say to them, "Come up
here!" And in a cloud they went up into heaven, while their enemies
looked on.[j] 13 In that same hour a great earthquake struck, and a tenth
of the city collapsed; the earthquake killed seven thousand persons.
The rest were filled with fear and gave glory to the God of heaven.[k]
14 The second woe is past; look, the third woe is coming quickly.
15 The seventh angel sounded the trumpet. Loud voices were heard in
heaven, declaring,

"The kingdom of the world has become
the possession of our Lord and of his Christ,
and he shall be king through all the ages."[l]

16 And the twenty-four elders, who sit on their thrones before God,
prostrated themselves, faces to the ground, and worshiped God,[m]
17 saying,

"We give you thanks, Lord God Almighty,
the one who is and who was,
because you have taken up your great power
and have begun your reign.[n]
18 Furious were the nations,
and now your anger has arrived,
the moment for judging the dead,
for paying their reward to your slaves the prophets,
to the saints, and to all who revere your name,
the lowly and the great alike,
and for ruining the ruiners of the earth."[o]

19 Then the temple of God in heaven was thrown open, and inside it
the ark of his covenant came into view, and there came lightning and
rumbling and thunder, an earthquake and a great hailstorm.

Notes

- a (11:1) Reed: a measuring rod; compare Ezek 40:3; Zech 2:1–2. *Was told*: literally "saying."
- b (11:2) Forty-two months: this equals three and a half years, the span named in Dan 7:25; 12:7; compare verse 3 and 12:6, 14; 13:5. Westcott and Hort bracket "and" in the Greek number. *Omit*: literally "cast out outside." *The nations*: or "the Gentiles."
- c (11:3) Twelve hundred and sixty days: the same span as forty-two months, counting thirty days to a month.
- d (11:4) Zech 4:3, 11–14, where the Hebrew has *ʾadon*, "lord," not the divine name.
- e (11:5) Compare Jer 5:14; 2 Kgs 1:10–12.
- f (11:6) Compare 1 Kgs 17:1; Exod 7:17–20.
- g (11:7) Compare Dan 7:3, 7, 21.
- h (11:8) In prophetic language: literally "spiritually." *Sodom*: perhaps "burning." *Egypt*: from the Greek *Aigyptos*; the Hebrew name is *Mitsrayim*.
- i (11:11) Ezek 37:5, 10. Westcott and Hort bracket "the" before "three" and "into" before "them."
- j (11:12) Compare 2 Kgs 2:11.
- k (11:13) At that very hour: not a clock time but "at that moment." *Seven thousand people*: literally "names of people, seven thousand."
- l (11:15) Ps 2:2. *Christ*: Greek *Christos*, "anointed one," translating the Hebrew *mashiaḥ*, "Messiah."
- m (11:16) Who sit: Westcott and Hort bracket the article before "before God."
- n (11:17) Who are and who were: later manuscripts add "and who are coming." *Lord God Almighty*: see the note on 1:8.
- o (11:18) Ps 2:1; 115:13.

Chapter 12

1 A great sign was seen in heaven: a woman wrapped in the sun, with
the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars on her head. 2
She was pregnant, and she was crying out in labor, in anguish to give
birth. 3 Another sign was seen in heaven as well: a great red dragon,
having seven heads and ten horns, and wearing seven royal crowns
on its heads.[a] 4 Its tail dragged down a third of heaven's stars and flung
them onto the earth. The dragon took its stand before the woman
who was about to give birth, in order to swallow her child as soon as
it was born.[b] 5 And she bore a child, a son, who is destined to govern
every nation with a rod of iron. Her child, though, was caught up to
God and to his throne.[c] 6 The woman herself fled into the wilderness,

to a spot God had prepared for her, where she would be fed for twelve hundred sixty days.

7 A battle then broke out in heaven. Michael and his angels waged
war against the dragon, and the dragon with his angels fought back,[d]
8 but they lost the battle, and heaven had room for them no longer.
9 and the great dragon was cast out: that primeval serpent, called the
Devil and Satan, who leads the whole world astray. It was cast down
to the earth, and its angels were cast down with it.[e]
10 Then a loud voice in heaven said,

"Salvation and strength have come at last,
along with the kingdom of our God
and the authority of his Christ;
for the prosecutor of our brothers and sisters,
who charged them before our God both day and night,
has been hurled down.[f]
11 They overcame him by the Lamb's blood
and by the word of their testimony,
and did not love their lives, even when facing death.
12 So be glad, you heavens,
and all who make your home in them!
But woe to the earth and to the sea,
because the devil has descended to you
in great fury, aware that his time is short!"[g]

13 On seeing that it had been cast down to the earth, the dragon went
in pursuit of the woman, the one who had borne the male child. 14
Yet the woman received the two wings of the great eagle, to fly away
into the wilderness, to the place prepared for her, where she is fed
for a season, two seasons, and half a season, out of the serpent's
sight.[h] 15 And from its mouth the serpent poured out water after the
woman, like a river, to sweep her away with the flood. 16 The earth,
however, rescued the woman. It opened its mouth and gulped down
the river that the dragon had spouted from its own mouth. 17 Furious
at the woman, the dragon went away to wage war against the others
among her children, those who obey the commands of God and bear
the witness of Jesus.[i]

Notes

- a (12:3) Diadems: royal crowns, as distinct from the victor's wreath (Greek *stephanos*). Compare Dan 7:7.
- b (12:4) Compare Dan 8:10.
- c (12:5) Ps 2:9; Isa 66:7.
- d (12:7) Michael: Hebrew "who is like God?"; the angelic prince of Dan 10:13, 21; 12:1.
- e (12:9) Ancient serpent: compare Gen 3:1–15.
- f (12:10) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters. *Accuser*: compare Job 1:6–11; Zech 3:1.
- g (12:12) Compare Isa 44:23; 49:13.
- h (12:14) Dan 7:25; 12:7; that is, three and a half years. *Two times*: literally "times." Compare Exod 19:4.
- i (12:17) Children: literally "seed."

Chapter 13

1 And it took its stand on the sand of the seashore. ¶Out of the sea
I saw a beast emerging; it had ten horns and seven heads, a diadem
on each of its ten horns, and names of blasphemy on its heads.[a] 2 The
creature I saw looked like a leopard, with paws like a bear's and a
mouth like a lion's. The dragon gave it his own power and throne,
along with extensive authority.[b] 3 One of its heads looked as if it had
been slaughtered to death, but its deadly wound was healed, and the
whole earth went after the beast in amazement.[c] 4 They worshiped
the dragon because it had given the authority to the beast, and they
worshiped the beast as well, asking, "Who is like the beast, and who
can wage war against it?"[d] 5 It received a mouth that spoke arrogant
words and blasphemy, and it received authority to act for forty-two
months.[e] 6 It opened its mouth to speak slanders against God, to curse
his name and his tent, those who live in heaven.[f] 7 Leave was given
it, too, to make war on the saints and defeat them, and to hold power
over every tribe, people, tongue and nation.[g] 8 Every inhabitant of the
earth will worship it, all those whose names were not recorded, from
the world's founding, in the book of life belonging to the slaughtered
Lamb.[h]
9 If anyone has an ear, let him listen:

10 Whoever is meant for captivity
will go to captivity;
whoever kills by the sword
must be killed by the sword.

Here is the call for the endurance and faithfulness of God's holy people.[i]

11 Then I saw a second beast ascending from the earth, with two horns like those of a lamb, yet it spoke like a dragon. 12 It wields all the authority of the first beast, acting before its eyes, and it causes the earth and those living on it to worship the first beast, the one whose deadly wound had been healed.[j] 13 It performs great signs, even bringing fire down out of heaven onto the earth in full view of everyone.[k] 14 Through the signs it was permitted to do before the beast, it misleads those living on the earth, instructing them to fashion an image of the beast who had received the sword stroke and yet lived. 15 It was also permitted to impart a spirit to the beast's statue, so that the statue itself would talk and would bring about the execution of all who would not bow before it.[l] 16 Everyone, the lowly and the mighty, the wealthy and the needy, the free and the enslaved, it compels to receive a mark on the right hand or the forehead,[m] 17 so that nobody can buy or sell without having the mark—the name of the beast or the number that stands for its name.[n] 18 Here is wisdom: whoever has insight should calculate the beast's number, for it stands for a person; its number is 666.[o]

Notes

- a (13:1) And it took its stand on the sand of the seashore: many modern editions number these words 12:18. *It* is the dragon; later manuscripts read "I stood," attaching the words to John's vision. *Names of blasphemy*: some manuscripts read "a name of blasphemy." Compare Dan 7:2–7.
- b (13:2) Compare Dan 7:4–6.
- c (13:3) Slaughtered to death: the same Greek word that is used of the Lamb in 5:6.
- d (13:4) Compare Exod 15:11.
- e (13:5) Compare Dan 7:8, 11, 20, 25. Westcott and Hort bracket "and" in the Greek number.
- f (13:6) His tent: that is, his dwelling place. Later manuscripts read "his tent and those who live in heaven."

- g (13:7) Leave was given it, too, to make war on the saints and defeat them: Westcott and Hort bracket these words, which P47, Alexandrinus and Ephraemi omit. Compare Dan 7:21.
- h (13:8) Since the founding of the world: these words may instead go with "slain," "the Lamb slain since the founding of the world"; compare 17:8. *Everyone whose name*: literally "whose name," in the singular.
- i (13:10) Jer 15:2; 43:11. *Kills*: Westcott and Hort read "will kill"; Alexandrinus, as reported, reads "is to be killed," which would yield the sense that anyone fated to be slain by the sword is slain by it. *Here the saints are called to*: literally "here is the endurance and the faith of the saints."
- j (13:12) On its behalf: literally "before it," "in its presence."
- k (13:13) Compare 1 Kgs 18:38.
- l (13:15) Breath: or "spirit." Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek conjunction before "everyone." Compare Dan 3:5–6.
- m (13:16) Mark: Greek *charagma*, a brand or stamp; the word was also used of the impression on coins and official seals.
- n (13:17) So that: Westcott and Hort bracket "and" before these words.
- o (13:18) Work out: literally "count," "reckon," using the ancient practice of giving each letter a numerical value (gematria). *A human number*: or "the number of a person." *Six hundred and sixty-six*: so Westcott and Hort and most manuscripts. P115 (3rd–4th century), Codex Ephraemi and some others read "six hundred and sixteen," and Irenaeus (about AD 180) knew of copies with that number. Both totals can be obtained from the Hebrew letters of "Nero Caesar" in different spellings, though many other solutions have been proposed.

Chapter 14

1 I looked, and the Lamb was there, standing on Mount Zion! Along
with him, 144,000 people bore on their foreheads his name and the
name of his Father.[a] 2 And out of heaven I heard a sound like the
rushing of great waters and like loud thunder rolling; the voice that
I heard was like that of harpists accompanying themselves on their
harps. 3 They sing what seems a new song before the throne and
before the four living creatures and the elders. And none was able
to learn the song except for those 144,000 who have been bought
out of the earth. 4 They are the ones who kept themselves unsoiled
by women, being virgins; they are the followers of the Lamb, going
wherever he leads. They were bought out of humanity as firstfruits
offered to God and to the Lamb,[b] 5 and in their speech no lie was found;
they are without blemish.[c]

6 Next I saw another angel in flight high overhead, bringing an everlasting gospel to announce to earth's inhabitants, to every nation, tribe, tongue and people.[d] 7 With a loud voice he said, "Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgment has arrived. Worship the maker of heaven and earth, of the sea and the springs of water."[e]
8 Another angel, a second, followed and said, "She has fallen! Fallen is Babylon the great, who gave all the nations a drink of the wine of her raging immorality!"[f]
9 Next, a third angel came after them, saying in a mighty voice, "If anyone worships the beast and its statue, and gets a mark on his forehead or on his hand, 10 he too will drink the wine of God's anger, mixed full strength in the cup of his wrath. He will be tortured in fire and brimstone before the holy angels and before the Lamb.[g] 11 The smoke of their torment goes up forever and ever. Day and night there is no rest for those who worship the beast and its image, or for anyone who takes the mark of its name."[h] 12 Here is the call for endurance on the part of the holy people, who keep God's commandments and the faith of Jesus.[i]
13 And I heard a voice speak from heaven: "Write: Blessed from this moment are the dead who die in the Lord." "Yes," the Spirit says, "let them find relief from their labors, for their deeds accompany them."[j]
14 As I watched, a white cloud appeared, and on it sat someone resembling a son of man; on his head was a crown of gold, and in his hand a keen-edged sickle.[k] 15 And a different angel emerged from the temple, shouting with a powerful voice to the one who sat upon the cloud: "Send out your sickle and harvest, for the hour to harvest has come, because the earth's crop has dried out."[l] 16 He who sat on the cloud cast his sickle onto the earth, and the earth's harvest was gathered in.
17 Out of the heavenly temple came yet another angel, and he as well held a keen-edged sickle. 18 And from the altar there came out yet another angel, who has charge over the fire. He called out with a strong voice to the holder of the sharp sickle, "Send out your sharp sickle and collect the clusters of grapes on the earth's vine, for its grapes have reached full ripeness."[m] 19 The angel cast his sickle onto the earth and harvested its grapes, flinging them into the vast wine-

press of God's fury. [20] Outside the city the grapes were trampled in the press, and out of it poured blood, rising to the horses' bridles, across a distance of about 180 miles.[n]

Notes

- a (14:1) Zion: the hill of Jerusalem's temple, and a name for the city; perhaps "fortress." *His name and*: later manuscripts omit these words.
- b (14:4) Virgins: Greek *parthenoi*, here masculine, perhaps picturing holy-war purity (compare Deut 23:9–10; 1 Sam 21:5) or faithfulness to God in contrast with spiritual prostitution.
- c (14:5) Compare Zeph 3:13; Isa 53:9. Later manuscripts add "before the throne of God."
- d (14:6) Gospel: Greek *euangelion*, "good news." *Another*: some manuscripts omit this word.
- e (14:7) The hour: the appointed time, not a time of day. Compare Exod 20:11; Ps 146:6.
- f (14:8) Isa 21:9; Jer 51:7–8. *Babylon*: the Greek form of the Hebrew *Bavel*; the Akkadian *Bab-ili* means "gate of god," while Gen 11:9 links it with Hebrew *balal*, "confuse." Here it is a code name for a great city, probably Rome (compare 1 Pet 5:13). *Passionate immorality*: literally "the wine of the passion of her immorality"; the Greek *thymos* can mean both "passion" and "wrath." *A second angel*: Westcott and Hort bracket "angel."
- g (14:10) Compare Isa 51:17; Jer 25:15; Gen 19:24.
- h (14:11) Compare Isa 34:10.
- i (14:12) The faith of Jesus: or "their faith in Jesus," or "faithfulness to Jesus."
- j (14:13) From now on: the Greek *ap' arti* may instead go with what follows: "From now on, yes, says the Spirit."
- k (14:14) Dan 7:13.
- l (14:15) Ripe: literally "dried," that is, fully ripe. Compare Joel 3:13.
- m (14:18) Came: Westcott and Hort bracket this verb and the article before "who has authority." *Authority over the fire*: compare 8:3–5.
- n (14:20) About 180 miles: Greek "1,600 stadia," about 300 km; a stadion was about 607 feet (185 m). The number may be symbolic (40 × 40, or 4 × 4 × 100). Compare Isa 63:1–6; Joel 3:13.

Chapter 15

[1] And I saw another portent in heaven, large and astonishing: seven angels holding the seven final plagues, since by them God's wrath is completed.

2 I also saw what looked like a glassy sea mingled with fire, and the
victors over the beast, over its likeness, and over its name's number
stood beside the glassy sea, holding God's harps.[a]
3 They are chanting the song of Moses, God's slave, and the song of
the Lamb:
"Mighty and astonishing are the things you do,
O Lord God, Ruler over all!
Upright and true are your paths,
King of the ages![b]
4 Lord, who will fail to fear you
and give glory to your name?
You alone are holy.
Every nation will come
and bow low before you,
for your judgments stand revealed."[c]
5 After these things I saw it: the sanctuary of the tent of testimony in
heaven was opened,[d] 6 and the seven angels holding the seven plagues
emerged from it, clothed in stone, pure and shining, and wearing gold
sashes about their breasts.[e] 7 Then one of the four living creatures
gave the seven angels seven golden bowls full of the wrath of God,
who lives forever and ever. 8 And the temple was filled with smoke
from the glory of God and from his power, and no one could enter the
temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels were completed.[f]

Notes

- a (15:2) Beside: or "on." *Harps of God*: that is, harps given by God, or harps for the worship of God.
- b (15:3) Exod 15:1–18; Deut 32:4; Ps 111:2; 139:14. *Moses*: explained in Exod 2:10 by Hebrew *mashah*, "draw out." *Lord God Almighty*: see the note on 1:8. *King of the ages*: so Westcott and Hort, with P47 and Sinaiticus as first written; Alexandrinus and many others read "King of the nations," and later manuscripts "King of the saints."
- c (15:4) Jer 10:7; Ps 86:9; Mal 1:11. In Jer 10:7 the Hebrew has no divine name; in Ps 86:9 it has *'Adonay*, "Lord."
- d (15:5) Tent of testimony: the tabernacle (Exod 38:21; 40:34–35 in the Greek Old Testament).
- e (15:6) Clothed in stone: so Westcott and Hort, following Alexandrinus and Ephraemi, perhaps picturing robes set with precious stones (compare Ezek 28:13).

Many manuscripts read *linon*, “linen,” for *lithon*, “stone.” Westcott and Hort bracket the article before “with the seven plagues.”

- f (15:8) Compare Exod 40:34–35; 1 Kgs 8:10–11; Isa 6:4.

Chapter 16

1 A loud voice from the temple then called to the seven angels, “Go,
empty the seven bowls of God’s fury onto the earth.”
2 The first angel went off and emptied his bowl onto the land, and
ugly, festering sores appeared on those who wore the beast’s mark
and bowed down to its image.[a]
3 Then the second angel emptied his bowl into the sea, and the water
turned into blood like a dead man’s, and every living creature in the
sea perished.[b]
4 Then the third emptied his bowl into the rivers and the water
sources, and these turned into blood.
5 And I heard the angel who presides over the waters declaring,
“You are righteous—who are and who were, the Holy One—
because you have rendered this verdict;[c]
6 they shed the blood of the holy and of the prophets,
and blood you have given them to drink;
they have earned it!”
7 And I heard the altar answer,
“Yes, O Lord God, the Almighty,
your verdicts are true and righteous!”[d]
8 The fourth emptied his bowl onto the sun, and the sun was permitted
to burn people with its fire. 9 People were seared by tremendous heat,
and they cursed God’s name—the God who holds power over these
plagues—and refused to repent and to glorify him.
10 Then the fifth emptied his bowl onto the throne of the beast, and its
realm was darkened. People chewed their tongues in anguish[e] 11 and
reviled the God of heaven for their sufferings and sores, yet they did
not repent of their works.
12 Then the sixth emptied his bowl onto the great Euphrates River. Its
water dried up, so that a road lay ready for the kings from the east.[f]
13 And from the dragon’s mouth, from the mouth of the beast, and

from the mouth of the false prophet, I watched three unclean spirits emerge, which resembled frogs.[g] 14 These are spirits of demons that do signs; they travel out to the rulers of the entire world to gather them for the war of that great day belonging to God, the Almighty. 15 ("Notice, I come as a thief does! Happy is the one who stays alert and holds on to his clothing, so that he need not walk naked and have his shame seen.") 16 And they gathered the kings together at the place that is called Harmagedon in Hebrew.[h]

17 The seventh angel emptied his bowl upon the air, and from the sanctuary, from the throne, a great voice called, "It is finished!"[i] 18 Lightning flashed, there was rumbling and thunder, and a great earthquake struck, the like of which had not happened since humans first lived on the earth, so violent was the quake.[j] 19 The great city broke into three pieces, and the nations' cities collapsed. Babylon the great came to mind before God, and he made her drink the cup brimming with the wine of his fierce anger. 20 Every island vanished; the mountains were nowhere to be seen. 21 And great hailstones, weighing about a talent, fell from the sky upon people, and people blasphemed God because of the plague of hail; for that plague was extremely severe.[k]

Notes

- a (16:2) Compare Exod 9:9–11.
- b (16:3) Compare Exod 7:17–21.
- c (16:5) The Holy One: Westcott and Hort bracket the article. Later manuscripts read "and who will be."
- d (16:7) Lord God, the Almighty: see the note on 1:8. Compare Ps 19:9.
- e (16:10) Compare Exod 10:21–23.
- f (16:12) From the east: literally "from the rising of the sun." Westcott and Hort bracket the article before "Euphrates." Compare Isa 11:15; Jer 50:38.
- g (16:13) Compare Exod 8:2–7.
- h (16:16) Harmagedon: traditionally "Armageddon"; probably Hebrew *har Megiddo*, "mountain of Megiddo," the site of famous battles (Judg 5:19; 2 Kgs 23:29). Some manuscripts read "Mageddon."
- i (16:17) From the throne: later manuscripts read "of heaven, from the throne."
- j (16:18) Compare Dan 12:1.

- k (16:21) About seventy pounds: literally “about a talent’s weight”; the talent was the largest ancient unit of weight, about 30–35 kg (65–75 pounds), though its value varied. Compare Exod 9:23–25.

Chapter 17

1 Then there came one of the seven angels who had been carrying
the seven bowls, and he told me, “Come along! I will let you see the
condemnation of the notorious prostitute who sits beside the many
waters,[a] 2 the one with whom earth’s kings have committed immoral-
ity, and with the wine of whose immorality the earth’s inhabitants
have grown drunk.” 3 In the Spirit he took me away to a wilderness.
There I noticed a woman seated upon a scarlet beast that was covered
with blasphemous names and had seven heads and ten horns. 4 The
woman wore purple and scarlet, and was resplendent with gold,
jewels, and pearls. A gold cup brimming with detestable things and
with the foulness of her immorality was in her hand.[b] 5 Across her
forehead a name was written, a mystery: “Babylon the great, mother
of the prostitutes and of the abominations of the earth.”[c] 6 The woman,
I noticed, was drunk with the blood of the holy people and with the
blood of Jesus’s witnesses. And when I saw her, I wondered greatly.[d]
7 The angel said, “Why do you wonder? Let me explain the secret of
the woman, and of the beast that bears her, which has seven heads
and ten horns. 8 The beast that you saw existed once and exists no
longer; it is going to rise from the abyss and then head for ruin.
Earth’s inhabitants whose names have not, since the world was
founded, been entered in the book of life will marvel at the sight of the
beast, because it existed once, exists no longer, and yet will appear.[e]
9 Here is something that calls for a mind with insight: the seven heads
stand for seven hills, where the woman has her seat. They also stand
for seven kings;[f] 10 five are fallen, one is living, and the last has still
to come; and whenever he comes, he is to remain a little while. 11
As for the beast that once was and now is not, it is itself an eighth,
but it springs from the seven, and it is heading for destruction. 12 The
ten horns that you saw are ten kings. They have not yet received a
kingdom, but for a single hour they receive authority as kings along-
side the beast.[g] 13 They share a single purpose, and they surrender

their might and their authority to the beast. 14 These will fight against
the Lamb, yet the Lamb will triumph over them, because Lord of lords
he is, and King of kings; and with him are the called, the chosen, and
the faithful ones."[h]
15 He says to me: "Those waters that you saw, on which the prostitute
is seated, stand for peoples and crowds and nations and languages. 16
And the ten horns you saw, along with the beast—they will hate the
prostitute, strip her of everything and leave her naked, eat her flesh,
and burn what remains of her with fire.[i] 17 It is God who has moved
their hearts to accomplish his intention, to act with one accord and
yield their royal power to the beast until what God has spoken comes
to pass. 18 The woman you saw is the great city that holds sovereignty
over the kings of the earth."

Notes

- a (17:1) Beside many waters: compare Jer 51:13, of Babylon on the Euphrates and its canals.
- b (17:4) Compare Jer 51:7.
- c (17:5) A mystery: or "a name of mystery," that is, a symbolic name.
- d (17:6) Witnesses: Greek *martyres*, the source of the English word "martyrs."
- e (17:8) Compare Dan 7:3.
- f (17:9) Mountains: Greek *orē*, "mountains" or "hills"; Rome was famous as the city of seven hills. *They are also seven kings*: in the Greek these words begin verse 10.
- g (17:12) For a single hour: that is, for a very short time. Compare Dan 7:24.
- h (17:14) Compare Deut 10:17; Dan 2:47.
- i (17:16) In fire: Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek preposition.

Chapter 18

1 After these things I saw a different angel coming down out of
heaven. He possessed great authority, and the earth shone with his
glory.[a]
2 He shouted in a mighty voice:

"Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great!
She has turned into a dwelling for demons,
a lockup for every unclean spirit,
a lockup for every unclean and loathsome bird,
and a lockup for every unclean and loathsome beast.[b]

3 For from the wine of her passionate immorality
all the nations have drunk,
and the kings of the earth fornicated with her,
and the merchants of the earth grew rich
from the power of her luxury."[c]
4 Another voice from heaven I heard, crying,
"My people, leave her,
so you take no part in her sins
and no portion of her plagues;[d]
5 For her sins have piled up to the sky,
and God has recalled her crimes.[e]
6 Give back to her what she has given,
and pay her twice over according to her deeds;
in the cup that she mixed for others, mix twice as much for her.[f]
7 Give her pain and mourning
to match the glory she gave herself and her wanton luxury.
In her heart she boasts,
'Enthroned as a queen I sit;
widow I am not,
and mourning I shall never know.'[g]
8 Therefore, in a single day her plagues will arrive:
pestilence, mourning, and famine,
and she will be consumed by fire,
for strong is the Lord God who has judged her."[h]
9 The kings of the earth, who were immoral with her and shared her luxury, will weep and mourn over her as they see the smoke of her burning.
10 Keeping their distance for terror at her torment, they will cry,
"Alas, alas, great city,
Babylon, city of might!
In a single hour your doom has fallen!"[i]
11 And the merchants of the earth are weeping and mourning over her, because nobody buys their merchandise any longer:[j]

12 a cargo of gold, silver, jewels, and pearls; of fine linen, purple cloth,
silk, and scarlet; of all kinds of citron wood and every article of ivory;
of every article of expensive wood, and of bronze, iron, and marble;[k]
13 and cinnamon, spices, incense, perfume, and frankincense; and
wine, oil, fine flour, and grain; and cattle and sheep and horses and
carriages; and bodies—that is, human souls.[l]
14 "The ripe fruit you craved with all your soul
has left you,
and all your rich and dazzling things
are lost to you,
and never again will people find them."[m]
15 Those who traded in these goods and made their fortunes from
her will keep their distance, terrified at her torment, crying and
mourning,
16 saying,
"Alas, alas, that great city,
which wore fine linen, purple, and scarlet,
and was gilded with gold,
with precious stones and pearls![n]
17 In a single hour such great wealth was devastated!" ¶Every ship-
master, everyone sailing to any destination, the sailors, and all who
make their living from the sea remained at a distance[o]
18 and shouted, as they saw the smoke rising from her burning, "Which
city was like this great city?"[p]
19 They flung dust on their heads, crying and mourning, and they
shouted,
"Alas, alas, great city,
whose costly wealth made rich
all who owned ships at sea!
In a single hour she is ruined."[q]
20 "Rejoice over her, O heaven,
you holy people, apostles, and prophets,
because God has pronounced your sentence on her!"[r]
21 Then one mighty angel picked up a boulder like a huge millstone
and flung it into the sea, with these words:

"Just so, in a violent plunge,
Babylon the great city will be hurled down,
and nobody will find her again.[s]
22 No more will the music of harp and song,
of pipe and trumpet,
be heard within you;
never again will any craftsman of any trade
be found within you;
never again will the grinding of the mill
be heard within you;[t]
23 No lamp will ever again give light in you;
never again will the voices of a bridegroom and a bride sound within you.
Your merchants were the world's great men,
and by your sorcery all the nations were led astray.[u]
24 In her the blood of prophets and of holy people was found,
together with the blood of everyone slaughtered on earth."

Notes

- a (18:1) Compare Ezek 43:2.
- b (18:2) Isa 21:9; 13:21; 34:11–15; Jer 50:39. *Prison*: or "lair." *And a prison for every foul and hated beast*: so Alexandrinus and some other manuscripts; Westcott and Hort place these words in the margin and read "a prison for every foul and hated bird."
- c (18:3) Have fallen: so Westcott and Hort; many manuscripts read "have drunk." *Wine*: Westcott and Hort bracket "the wine."
- d (18:4) Jer 51:45; Isa 48:20; 52:11.
- e (18:5) Compare Jer 51:9.
- f (18:6) Jer 50:29; Ps 137:8. Westcott and Hort bracket the article before "double."
- g (18:7) Isa 47:7–8.
- h (18:8) Single day: compare Isa 47:9. *The Lord God*: Westcott and Hort bracket "Lord." Compare Jer 50:34, where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.
- i (18:10) Alas: Greek *ouai*, translated "woe" elsewhere. *In a single hour*: that is, suddenly; not a clock time. So also verses 17 and 19.
- j (18:11) Compare Ezek 27:1–36, the lament over Tyre.
- k (18:12) Citron wood: a fragrant North African wood prized for luxury tables.
- l (18:13) Spice: Greek *amōmon*, an aromatic plant from India. *Ointment*: Greek *myron*, perfumed oil. *Bodies*: Greek *sōmata*, a common term for slaves in

commercial documents. *Even human lives*: literally “and souls of people”; compare Ezek 27:13.

- m (18:14) No one will find them: literally “they will never find them.”
- n (18:16) With gold: Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek preposition.
- o (18:17) Everyone who sails anywhere: literally “everyone sailing to a place”; later manuscripts read “all the company on ships.”
- p (18:18) Compare Ezek 27:32.
- q (18:19) Compare Ezek 27:30.
- r (18:20) Has given judgment for you against her: literally “has judged your judgment from her.” Compare Deut 32:43.
- s (18:21) Compare Jer 51:63–64.
- t (18:22) Of any trade: Westcott and Hort bracket these words. Compare Ezek 26:13; Jer 25:10.
- u (18:23) Jer 7:34; 16:9; 25:10; Isa 23:8. Westcott and Hort bracket the article before “merchants.”

Chapter 19

1 After this I heard what seemed a great noise, the voice of an immense
multitude in heaven, saying,
“Hallelujah!
Salvation and glory and power are our God’s,[a]
2 because true and just are his judgments.
He condemned the great prostitute,
the one who corrupted the earth by her immorality,
and he has taken vengeance on her for the blood of his slaves.”[b]
3 And a second time they cried out,
“Hallelujah!
Her smoke rises for ever and ever.”[c]
4 The twenty-four elders and the four living creatures fell prostrate
and worshiped the God seated on the throne, saying,
“Amen! Hallelujah!”[d]
5 A voice came out of the throne, and it said,
“Give praise to our God,
all his slaves,
and those who fear him,
the small and the great.”[e]

6 Then I heard what seemed the voice of an immense multitude, like
the sound of rushing water and like the rumble of loud thunder,
saying,
"Hallelujah!
Because the Lord our God,
the Almighty, has taken up his reign.[f]
7 Let us rejoice and exult,
and let us give the glory to him,
for the marriage of the Lamb has arrived,
and his bride has prepared herself.[g]
8 and she was given clothing
of bright, clean fine linen to wear."
(The fine linen, you see, stands for the righteous deeds of the holy
people.)
9 Then he told me, "Write: Blessed are the people invited to the mar-
riage banquet of the Lamb!" And he told me, "These words are God's
own truth."[h] 10 I threw myself down in front of his feet to worship
him. But he told me, "Never do that! I am only a slave like you and
your brothers who maintain the testimony of Jesus. Worship God!
The testimony about Jesus is what inspires prophecy."[i]
11 Then I saw heaven standing open, and a white horse appeared.
Its rider is named Faithful and True, and he judges and wages war
in righteousness.[j] 12 His eyes blaze like fire, and many diadems are
on his head. A name is inscribed on him that no one understands
but he himself.[k] 13 He is clothed in a robe sprinkled with blood, and
his name is called the Word of God.[l] 14 Heaven's armies rode behind
him on white horses, dressed in pure white linen. 15 A sharp sword
extends from his mouth, so that with it he may strike the nations;
he will shepherd them with a rod of iron. And he himself treads the
winepress that holds the fierce wrath of God the Almighty.[m] 16 The
title "King of kings and Lord of lords" is inscribed upon his cloak, on
his thigh.
17 Then I noticed an angel standing in the sun. He called out in
a mighty voice to every bird that flies across midheaven: "Come,
assemble for God's great banquet,[n] 18 so that you may eat the flesh

of kings, of generals, and of the strong; the flesh of horses and of those who sit on them; and the flesh of everyone, free and slave, small and great."[o]

19 I saw the beast as well, and earth's kings and their armies, mustered to do battle with the horse's rider and his army. 20 The beast was seized, and so was the false prophet who had done the signs in its presence, signs that had misled those who took the beast's mark and bowed down to its image. Both of them were flung alive into the fiery lake that blazes with sulfur. 21 All the others were slain by the sword that issues from the rider's mouth, and every bird ate its fill of their flesh.

Notes

- a (19:1) Hallelujah: Hebrew *halelu-yah*, "praise Yah," *Yah* being a short form of *Yahweh*. In the New Testament the word occurs only in this chapter (verses 1, 3, 4, 6).
- b (19:2) Deut 32:43; 2 Kgs 9:7. *On her*: literally "from her hand."
- c (19:3) Isa 34:10.
- d (19:4) Ps 106:48.
- e (19:5) Ps 115:13; 134:1; 135:1.
- f (19:6) Our God: Westcott and Hort bracket "our." *The Lord our God, the Almighty*: see the note on 1:8. Compare Ps 93:1; 97:1, where the Hebrew has *Yahweh*.
- g (19:7) Bride: literally "wife."
- h (19:9) The angel: Greek "he"; compare 17:1.
- i (19:10) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters. *The testimony of Jesus*: either the witness Jesus gave, or the witness borne to him.
- j (19:11) Is called: Westcott and Hort bracket this word. Compare Isa 11:4.
- k (19:12) Later manuscripts add "names written and" before "a name written."
- l (19:13) Sprinkled: so Westcott and Hort, following some manuscripts; Alexandrinus and most others read "dipped in." Compare Isa 63:1–3.
- m (19:15) Ps 2:9; Isa 11:4; 63:3. Later manuscripts read "two-edged sword."
- n (19:17) With a loud voice: Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek preposition.
- o (19:18) Ezek 39:17–20. *Commanders*: see the note on 6:15.

Chapter 20

1 And I saw an angel come down from heaven; in his hand he held the key of the abyss, together with a massive chain. 2 He seized the dragon, that ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound

him fast for a thousand years.[a] 3 He flung it into the abyss, closed it
up, and set a seal over it, so that it could no longer mislead the nations
until the thousand years should be completed. After that it must be
let loose for a short while.
4 I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given to
them. I saw too the souls of those beheaded for the testimony of Jesus
and for the word of God, and of those who did not bow to the beast
or to its image, and did not accept the mark upon their forehead and
upon their hand. They lived and ruled with Christ a thousand years.[b]
5 The rest of the dead had no new life until the thousand years ended.
This is the first resurrection. 6 Blessed—and holy—are those who have
a place in the first resurrection. Over them the second death holds no
authority; instead they will be priests belonging to God and to Christ,
and for those thousand years they will reign with him.[c]
7 When the thousand years have run their course, Satan will be
released from his prison. 8 He will go out to mislead the nations at the
earth's four corners, Gog and Magog, and to muster them for battle;
they are as countless as the sand along the sea.[d] 9 They advanced over
the breadth of the earth and besieged the camp of the holy people, the
city that he loves. Then fire fell from heaven and consumed them.[e] 10
As for the devil who had led them astray, he was cast into the lake
of burning sulfur, in which the beast and the false prophet are also
found; there they will be in torment by day and by night through all
the ages.
11 Then I saw a great white throne, with the one seated upon it. Earth
and heaven fled from his face, and no place could be found for them. 12
And I saw the dead, important and unimportant alike, standing before
the throne. Scrolls were unrolled; then another scroll was unrolled—
the scroll of life. By the contents of the scrolls the dead were judged,
each according to his deeds.[f] 13 The sea yielded up the dead it held;
Death and Hades yielded up the dead they held; and each person was
judged by what he had done. 14 Death and Hades were thrown into
the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire.[g] 15 Whoever
was not listed in the scroll of life was hurled into the pool of fire.

Notes

- a (20:2) A thousand years: Latin *millennium*; so also in verses 3–7.
- b (20:4) Beheaded: literally “executed with the axe.” Compare Dan 7:9, 22.
- c (20:6) For the thousand years: Westcott and Hort bracket “the.”
- d (20:8) Gog and Magog: compare Ezek 38–39, where Gog is a ruler “of the land of Magog”; the meaning of the names is uncertain. Here both stand for the hostile nations.
- e (20:9) Compare 2 Kgs 1:10–12; Ezek 38:22. Later manuscripts read “from God out of heaven.”
- f (20:12) Compare Dan 7:10; 12:1.
- g (20:14) The lake of fire: Westcott and Hort print these words at the end of the verse; some manuscripts omit them.

Chapter 21

1 Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and
the first earth had vanished, and the sea is no more.[a]
2 I saw the holy city too—a new Jerusalem—descending from God out
of heaven, adorned like a bride made ready for her husband.[b]
3 A loud voice from the throne declared:
“Look! God’s tent is among human beings.
He will pitch it among them,
and they will be his peoples,
with God himself present among them as their God.[c]
4 Every tear will be wiped by him from their eyes.
Death will be no more;
no more mourning, no more crying, no more suffering,
for the former things have gone.”[d]
5 Then the one seated on the throne declared, “Look, I make every-
thing new!” And he said, “Write this down, because these words are
faithful and true.”[e] 6 Then he said to me, “They have come to pass!
I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the
thirsty one I will give as a gift out of the spring of life-giving water.[f]
7 Whoever conquers will have this as an inheritance; I will be his
God, and he will be my son.[g] 8 But for the cowards, the unbelieving,
the vile, murderers, fornicators, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars: the
lake that blazes with fire and sulfur will be their portion—this is the
second death.”[h]

9 And there approached me one of those seven angels, those having
the seven bowls that were filled with the final seven plagues; he spoke
with me and said, "Come here; I will point out to you the bride, the
Lamb's wife." 10 And in the Spirit he carried me off to a mountain great
and high, and he displayed to me the holy city Jerusalem as it came
down out of heaven from God,[i] 11 shining with the glory of God. Its
radiance was like a rare jewel, like jasper, crystal clear.[j] 12 It had a wall,
great and high; it had twelve gates, and over the gates twelve angels,
and engraved names, which are those of the twelve tribes of Israel's
sons.[k] 13 There were three gates facing east, three facing north, three
facing south, and three facing west. 14 The city's wall rested on twelve
foundations, and written on them were twelve names: those of the
twelve apostles of the Lamb.
15 The one speaking with me had a golden measuring rod, in order
to measure the city, along with its gates and its wall.[l] 16 The city
lies foursquare, with its length equal to its width. With the rod he
measured the city: about 1,400 miles. Its length, width, and height
are identical.[m] 17 Its wall he also measured, 216 feet, using a human
unit of measure, which was the angel's.[n] 18 Its wall was constructed of
jasper, and the city itself was pure gold, resembling clear glass. 19 The
foundations of the city's wall were adorned with all kinds of precious
stones: the first foundation was jasper; the second, sapphire; the
third, chalcedony; the fourth, emerald;[o] 20 the fifth sardonyx, the sixth
carnelian, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz,
the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst.[p] 21
And twelve pearls were the twelve gates—every gate fashioned from
one single pearl. The city's broad street was pure gold, transparent
as glass.[q]
22 No temple did I see in it, for the Lord God, the Almighty, is its
temple, and so is the Lamb.[r] 23 The city requires neither sun nor moon
to shine upon it, since God's glory gave it light, and it has the Lamb as
its lamp.[s] 24 The nations will walk by means of its light, and the kings
of the earth carry their glory into it.[t] 25 Its gates will not be closed
by day—and night will not exist there.[u] 26 They will carry the glory
and the honor of the nations into it. 27 Nothing profane will ever enter

it, nor anyone who commits abomination and falsehood, only those whose names are written in the Lamb's book of life.[v]

Notes

- a (21:1) Isa 65:17; 66:22.
- b (21:2) Compare Isa 52:1; 61:10.
- c (21:3) Lev 26:11–12; Ezek 37:27; Zech 2:10–11. *Dwelling*: literally "tent." *Peoples*: so Westcott and Hort; many manuscripts read "people." Some manuscripts add "as their God" at the end.
- d (21:4) Isa 25:8; 35:10; 65:19.
- e (21:5) Compare Isa 43:19.
- f (21:6) Isa 55:1. *They are accomplished*: literally "they have come to be." *Alpha … Omega*: see the note on 1:8.
- g (21:7) Echoing Ps 89:26–27 and 2 Sam 7:14.
- h (21:8) The faithless: or "the unbelieving." Later manuscripts add "and sinners" after "cowards."
- i (21:10) Compare Ezek 40:2.
- j (21:11) Compare Isa 60:1–2, 19.
- k (21:12) Compare Ezek 48:30–35.
- l (21:15) Compare Ezek 40:3–5.
- m (21:16) About 1,400 miles: Greek "12,000 stadia," about 2,200 km; a stadion was about 607 feet (185 m). The number is symbolic (12 × 1,000). The city is a cube, like the inner sanctuary of Solomon's temple (1 Kgs 6:20).
- n (21:17) 216 feet: Greek "144 cubits," about 65 m; a cubit was about 18 inches (45 cm). The figure (12 × 12) may refer to the wall's height or its thickness. *A human unit of measure, which was the angel's*: literally "a measure of a man, which is of an angel."
- o (21:19) The identification of several of these stones with their modern namesakes is uncertain. Compare the stones of the high priest's breastpiece (Exod 28:17–20) and of Ezek 28:13. *Sapphire*: probably lapis lazuli.
- p (21:20) Carnelian: Greek *sardion*; see the note on 4:3. *Chrysolite*: literally "gold stone," perhaps a yellow topaz. *Topaz*: perhaps peridot. *Jacinth*: Greek *hyakinthos*, a blue or violet stone.
- q (21:21) Compare Isa 54:11–12.
- r (21:22) The Lord God, the Almighty: see the note on 1:8.
- s (21:23) Isa 60:19–20.
- t (21:24) Isa 60:3, 5, 11. Later manuscripts read "the nations of those who are saved."
- u (21:25) Isa 60:11; Zech 14:7.
- v (21:27) Isa 52:1. *Anyone who commits*: Westcott and Hort bracket the article.

Chapter 22

1 Then he showed me a river of water that gives life, as clear as crystal,
issuing from the throne belonging to God and to the Lamb[a] 2 midway
along the city's broad street; and on this bank and that of the river
stood a tree of life, which yields twelve harvests, rendering its fruit
month by month. The tree's leaves serve to heal the nations.[b] 3 No
accursed thing will exist any longer. In the city will stand the throne
of God and the Lamb, and his slaves will worship him;[c] 4 they will see
his face, and his name will be on their foreheads.[d] 5 And night will
exist no longer; nor will they need the light of a lamp or of the sun,
for the Lord God will cast his light on them; and they will rule as
kings for ever and ever.[e]

6 And the angel said to me, "These words are faithful and true. The
Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, commissioned his angel
to show his slaves the things that must soon take place."[f] 7 "Look, I
am on my way soon! Blessed is whoever heeds the prophetic words
of this book."

8 I, John, am the one who heard these things and saw them. After I
had heard and seen, I prostrated myself in homage at the angel's feet
—the angel who was pointing these things out to me. 9 But he said
to me, "Do not do that! I am a slave together with you, with your
brothers the prophets, and with those who keep the words of this
book. Worship God."[g]

10 And he told me, "Do not seal up the words of this book's prophecy,
for the time is near.[h] 11 Let the one who does wrong go on doing wrong,
and let the one who is filthy go on being filthy; let the righteous go
on practicing righteousness, and let the holy go on being made holy."[i]

12 "Look, I am on my way soon, and my reward is with me, to give to
each one as his work deserves.[j] 13 I am the Alpha and the Omega, the
first and the last, the beginning and the end."

14 Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that the tree of life will be
theirs by right, and they may enter the city through its gates.[k] 15 Out-
side are the dogs, the sorcerers, the sexually immoral, the murderers,
the idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood.[l]

16 “I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify these things to you about the churches. I am the descendant of David and the root from which he sprang, the bright star of the morning.”[m]
17 The Spirit and the bride are saying, “Come!” And whoever hears should also say, “Come!” Whoever is thirsty should come; whoever wishes should receive the water of life as a gift.[n]
18 I give this warning to everyone who hears the words of this book’s prophecy: should anyone add to them, God will lay on him the plagues described in this book;[o] 19 and if anyone cuts anything from the words of the book containing this prophecy, God will cut off his allotment, whether in the tree of life or in the holy city—things written about in this book.[p]
20 The one who gives these testimonies says, “Certainly, I am on my way soon.” Amen! Come, Lord Jesus![q]
21 The grace of the Lord Jesus be with the saints.[r]

Notes

- a (22:1) Ezek 47:1–12; Zech 14:8.
- b (22:2) Tree of life: Gen 2:9; compare Ezek 47:12. *Down the middle of the city’s street*: these words may instead go with what follows: “Between the street and the river, on either side, stood the tree of life.” *Tree*: the Greek may be collective, “trees.”
- c (22:3) Compare Zech 14:11.
- d (22:4) Compare Ps 17:15; Exod 33:20.
- e (22:5) Isa 60:19; Dan 7:18, 27. *Give them light*: Westcott and Hort bracket the Greek preposition “upon.”
- f (22:6) The God of the spirits of the prophets: compare Num 16:22; 27:16. Later manuscripts read “the God of the holy prophets.”
- g (22:9) Brothers: Greek *adelphoi*, which includes sisters.
- h (22:10) Contrast Dan 12:4, 9.
- i (22:11) Compare Dan 12:10.
- j (22:12) Isa 40:10; 62:11; Prov 24:12.
- k (22:14) Who wash their robes: so Westcott and Hort, with Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus; later manuscripts read “who do his commandments.”
- l (22:15) Dogs: a term of contempt for the impure; compare Deut 23:18; Phil 3:2.
- m (22:16) Isa 11:1, 10; Num 24:17. *To you*: the Greek is plural.
- n (22:17) Isa 55:1.
- o (22:18) Compare Deut 4:2; 12:32.

- p (22:19) Tree of life: so Westcott and Hort and the early Greek manuscripts. The King James Version's "book of life" goes back to Erasmus, whose single Greek manuscript lacked the last verses of the book; he translated them from the Latin Vulgate, whose text in many copies reads *libro*, "book," for *ligno*, "tree."
- q (22:20) Quickly: Greek *tachy*, also "soon," as in 22:7, 12.
- r (22:21) Lord Jesus: Westcott and Hort bracket "Christ" after "Jesus." *With the saints*: so Westcott and Hort, with Sinaiticus; Alexandrinus reads "with all," and later manuscripts "with you all" or "with all the saints." Later manuscripts add "Amen."

1 Enoch

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

The Book of the Watchers (chapters 1–36)

1 The words of blessing of Enoch,[a] with which he blessed the chosen[b]
and the righteous who will be living in the day of distress, when all
the wicked and the godless are to be removed.
2 He took up his discourse[c] and said: Enoch was a righteous man;
God opened his eyes, and he saw a vision of the Holy One in heaven,
which the angels showed me. From them I heard everything, and from
them I understood what I saw, not for this generation but for one far
off that is yet to come.
3 Concerning the chosen I spoke, and I took up my discourse about
them:
The Great Holy One[d] will come out from his dwelling,
4 and the eternal God will tread upon the earth, on Mount Sinai.[e]
He will appear with his host,[f]
and appear in the strength of his might from the highest heaven.
5 All will be struck with fear,
and the Watchers[g] will tremble,
and great fear and shaking will seize them to the ends of the earth.
6 The high mountains will be shaken;
the lofty hills will be brought low
and will melt like wax before a flame.
7 The earth will be split wide apart,[h]
and everything on the earth will perish,
and there will be judgment upon all.
8 But with the righteous he will make peace;
he will guard the chosen,
and mercy will rest upon them.
They will all belong to God;

he will grant them his favor
and bless them all.
He will help them all;
light will shine upon them,
and he will make peace with them.
9 Look, he comes with myriads of his holy ones,[i]
to execute judgment upon all,
to destroy all the wicked,
and to convict all flesh
for all the works of their wickedness that they have wickedly done,
and for all the proud and harsh words that wicked sinners have spoken against him.

Notes

- a (1:1) *Enoch*: Hebrew *Ḥanokh*, probably "dedicated" or "initiated." He is the son of Jared and the seventh from Adam, who "walked with God" and was taken by God (Gen 5:18–24).
- b (1:1) Chosen: Geʿez *ḥeruyān*, traditionally "the elect"; so throughout the book.
- c (1:2) Discourse: Geʿez *messālē*, Greek *parabolē*, Aramaic *matla*: a solemn oracle or figurative speech, traditionally "parable." So throughout.
- d (1:3) The Great Holy One: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "the Holy and Great One." The Aramaic fragments reportedly use *qaddisha rabba*, "the Great Holy One," a favorite title for God in this book.
- e (1:4) Mount Sinai: compare Deut 33:2; Mic 1:3.
- f (1:4) He will appear with his host: so the Greek, "he will appear out of his camp"; Charles regarded the line as a doublet of the next.
- g (1:5) Watchers: Aramaic *ʿirin*, "wakeful ones," a class of angels (Dan 4:13, 17, 23). In this book the word usually refers to the angels who sinned (chapters 6–16).
- h (1:7) Split wide apart: so the Greek; the Ethiopic reads "sink."
- i (1:9) Myriads of his holy ones: literally "ten thousands." This verse is quoted in Jude 14–15. A fragment of the Aramaic (4QEn^{c}) reportedly preserves part of it.

Chapter 2

1 Consider everything that takes place in the sky: how the lights in the heavens do not change their paths, how each rises and sets in order at its own time and does not depart from its appointed law. 2 Look at the earth and pay attention to the things that happen on it from first to last: how steady they are, how nothing on earth changes, but all the works of God appear before you. 3 Consider summer and winter:

in them the whole earth is full of water, and cloud, dew, and rain lie over it.

Chapter 3

1 Observe and see how in winter every tree appears dried up, having dropped all its leaves, except fourteen trees that do not lose their foliage but keep the old leaves for two or three years until the new ones come.[a]

Notes

- a (3:1) Fourteen trees: so the Ethiopic; the Greek is lost here. The number may come from a list of evergreens in the Aramaic original, now lost.

Chapter 4

1 Observe again the days of summer, how the sun stands over the earth opposite it. You look for shade and shelter because of the heat of the sun, and the earth too burns with scorching heat, so that you cannot walk on the ground or on a rock because of its heat.

Chapter 5

1 Observe how the trees clothe themselves with green leaves and bear fruit. So pay attention and understand all his works, and recognize that he who lives forever made them this way.

2 All his works go on in this way from year to year forever, and all the tasks that they perform for him; their tasks do not change, but everything is done as God has ordained.

3 See how the sea and the rivers likewise perform their tasks and do not depart from his commands.

4 But you have not stood firm,
and you have not done the commandments of the Lord.
You have turned aside and spoken proud and harsh words
with your unclean mouths against his greatness.
You hard-hearted, you will find no peace!

5 Therefore you will curse your days,
and the years of your life will perish;
the years of your destruction will be multiplied in an everlasting

curse,
and you will find no mercy.
6 In those days you will make your names an everlasting curse for all the righteous;
by you all who curse will curse,
and all the sinners and the godless will swear by you.
For you, the godless, there will be a curse.
But all the righteous will rejoice;[a]
there will be forgiveness of sins,
and every mercy and peace and kindness.
There will be salvation for them, a good light.
But for all of you sinners there will be no salvation;
a curse will rest upon you all.
7 For the chosen there will be light and grace and peace,
and they will inherit the earth.
8 Then wisdom will be given to the chosen,
and they will all live and never sin again,
neither through godlessness nor through pride;
but those who have wisdom will be humble.
9 They will not go wrong again,
nor will they sin all the days of their life,
nor will they die from anger or wrath,
but they will complete the number of the days of their life.
Their lives will grow long in peace,
and the years of their joy will be many,
in everlasting gladness and peace,
all the days of their life.

Notes

- a (5:6) The righteous: this word is missing in the Ethiopic, which leaves a gap here; it is supplied from the sense and the Greek.

Chapter 6

1 Now when the human race had multiplied, in those days beautiful and lovely daughters were born to them. 2 The angels, the sons of heaven,[a] saw them and desired them, and they said to one another,

"Come, let us choose wives for ourselves from the daughters of men and father children for ourselves." [3] Shemihazah,[b] who was their leader, said to them, "I fear that you will not really agree to do this deed, and I alone will have to pay the penalty for a great sin." [4] They all answered him, "Let us all swear an oath and bind ourselves by curses on one another not to give up this plan, but to carry it out." [5] Then they all swore together and bound themselves by curses on one another to it. [6] They numbered two hundred in all, and in the days of Jared they descended[c] onto the peak of Mount Hermon.[d] They named it Mount Hermon because on it they had taken the oath and put themselves under curses. [7] These are the names of their leaders: Shemihazah, their leader; Arteqoph,[e] Ramtel, Kokabel, Tamiel, Ramiel, Danel, Ziqiel, Baraqel, Asael, Armaros, Batriel, Ananel, Zeqiel, Shamshiel, Sahriel, Turiel, Yomiel, and Sariel. [8] These are their chiefs over tens.[f]

Notes

- a (6:2) Sons of heaven: the angels; compare "sons of God" in Gen 6:2. Chapters 6–11 retell Gen 6:1–4.
- b (6:3) *Shemihazah*: so the Aramaic and Greek; Ethiopic *Semyāzā*. The name probably means "the Name has seen" or "my name has seen."
- c (6:6) *Jared*: Hebrew *Yered*, "descent," the father of Enoch (Gen 5:15–18). The book plays on the name: in his days the angels "descended."
- d (6:6) Hermon: the mountain is named from a root meaning "ban" or "devote under oath" (*ḥerem*); hence the wordplay with the curse-oath that they swore there. Compare Jubilees 4:15.
- e (6:7) The names are given in the Aramaic forms where these are reported from the fragments, otherwise in the Greek or Ethiopic forms; the Ethiopic spellings are badly corrupted. Most are formed with *-el*, "God," and a word for a natural phenomenon or skill. *Arteqoph* (Ethiopic *Arākiba*): "earth of the mighty one" (uncertain). *Ramtel* (Ethiopic *Rāmē'ēl*): "burning ash of God." *Kokabel*: "star of God." *Tamiel*: "perfection of God" (uncertain). *Ramiel*: "thunder of God" or "exalted of God." *Danel*: "God has judged." *Ziqiel* (Ethiopic *Ezeqeel*): "lightning flash of God." *Baraqel*: "lightning of God." *Asael*: "God has made." *Armaros*: perhaps from *Hermoni*, "the one of Hermon." *Batriel*: "rain of God" (uncertain). *Ananel*: "cloud of God." *Zeqiel* (Ethiopic *Zaqiel*): "sparks of God." *Shamshiel* (Ethiopic *Samsapeel*): "sun of God." *Sahriel* (Ethiopic *Satarel*): "moon of God." *Turiel*: "mountain of God." *Yomiel*: "day of God." *Sariel* (Ethiopic) or *Yehaddiel* (reported Aramaic): meaning uncertain.
- f (6:8) Chiefs over tens: each of the twenty leaders (counting Shemihazah) commanded ten of the two hundred.

Chapter 7

1 These, and all the others with them, took wives for themselves; each chose one for himself, and they began to go in to them and to defile themselves with them. They taught them sorcery and spells, and the cutting of roots, and showed them plants.[a] 2 The women became pregnant and bore great giants, whose height was three thousand cubits.[b] 3 They consumed everything that people had produced, and when people could no longer support them, 4 the giants turned against them and devoured human beings. 5 They began to sin against the birds, the animals, the creeping things, and the fish, and to devour one another's flesh, and they drank the blood. 6 Then the earth brought an accusation against the lawless ones.

Notes

- a (7:1) Plants: that is, the use of herbs for magic and medicine.
- b (7:2) Three thousand cubits: about 4,500 feet (1,350 m), reckoning the cubit at 18 inches (45 cm). The Ethiopic has "ells" (cubits); some Greek witnesses, in Syncellus, add that the giants fathered Nephilim, and the Nephilim fathered the Eliud.

Chapter 8

1 Asael[a] taught people to make swords and knives, shields and breastplates. He showed them the metals of the earth and how to work them, and bracelets and ornaments, the use of antimony[b] and the painting of the eyelids, all kinds of precious stones, and all coloring dyes. 2 There was a great deal of godlessness; they committed sexual immorality, they were led astray, and they became corrupt in all their ways. 3 Shemihazah taught spells and the cutting of roots; Armaros, the undoing of spells; Baraqel, the reading of lightning; Kokabel, the signs of the stars; Ziqiel, the signs of the flashes; Arteqoph, the signs of the earth; Shamshiel, the signs of the sun; and Sahriel, the courses of the moon.[c] 4 As people were perishing, they cried out, and their cry went up to heaven.

Notes

- a (8:1) *Asael*: so the Aramaic, reportedly, and the Greek (*Asaēl*), one of the leaders listed at 6:7; the Ethiopic has *Azazel* here and elsewhere, the name of the figure in the Day of Atonement ritual (Lev 16:8–10), and the two figures were merged in the tradition. *Asael* means "God has made."

- b (8:1) Antimony: a black powder used as eye paint; compare 2 Kgs 9:30.
- c (8:3) The skills match the names of the angels (see the note at 6:7). The Ethiopic list is shorter and corrupt (it has "Baraqiyal taught astrology, Kokabel the constellations, Ezeqeel the knowledge of the clouds"); this rendering follows the Greek more closely.

Chapter 9

1 Then Michael, Sariel,[a] Raphael, and Gabriel looked down from heaven and saw a great deal of blood being shed on the earth and all the lawlessness being done on the earth. 2 They said to one another, "The earth, stripped of its inhabitants,[b] raises the sound of their cry to the gates of heaven. 3 Now the souls of humankind are pleading with you, the holy ones of heaven: 'Bring our case before the Most High.'" 4 They said to the Lord of the ages:[c] "You are Lord of lords, God of gods, King of kings, God of the ages! Your glorious throne stands for every generation of the ages, and your name is holy, glorious, and blessed for all the ages! 5 You made everything, and you have authority over everything. All things are bare and open before you; you see everything, and nothing can hide from you. 6 You see what Asael has done: he has taught all wrongdoing on the earth and revealed the eternal secrets that were kept in heaven, which human beings were striving to learn.[d] 7 And Shemihazah, to whom you gave authority to rule over those who are with him, has taught spells. 8 They have gone in to the daughters of men on the earth, lain with the women, defiled themselves, and revealed to them every kind of sin. 9 The women have borne giants,[e] and through this the whole earth has been filled with blood and wrongdoing. 10 And now, look: the souls of those who have died are crying out and making their appeal to the gates of heaven. Their groaning has gone up and cannot cease because of the lawless deeds done on the earth. 11 You know all things before they happen. You see these things and allow them, and you do not tell us what we ought to do to them about these things."

Notes

- a (9:1) *Michael*: "Who is like God?" *Sariel*: "prince of God"; so the Greek and, reportedly, the Aramaic. The Ethiopic has *Uriel*, "God is my light." *Raphael*: "God has healed." *Gabriel*: "God is my strength" or "man of God."

- b (9:2) Stripped of its inhabitants: or "laid waste." The Greek reads "The voice of their cry, as they are destroyed on the earth, reaches the gates of heaven."
- c (9:4) The Lord of the ages: so the Ethiopic; the Greek has "to the Lord, the King."
- d (9:6) Which human beings were striving to learn: so the Ethiopic; one Greek text reads "which the sons of men practice."
- e (9:9) Giants: the Greek of Syncellus adds "bastards."

Chapter 10

1 Then the Most High, the Great Holy One, spoke. He sent Sariel[a] to
the son of Lamech,[b] 2 saying, "Go to Noah[c] and tell him in my name,
'Hide yourself!' Reveal to him the end that is coming: that the whole
earth will be destroyed, and a flood is about to come upon the whole
earth and destroy everything on it. 3 Now teach him so that he may
escape and his offspring may be preserved for all the generations of
the world."

4 To Raphael the Lord said, "Bind Asael hand and foot and throw him
into the darkness. Make an opening in the desert that is in Dudael,[d]
and throw him into it. 5 Lay rough and jagged rocks on him, cover
him with darkness, and let him stay there forever. Cover his face so
that he cannot see the light. 6 On the great day of judgment he will be
thrown into the fire. 7 Heal the earth that the angels have ruined, and
announce the healing of the earth, that I will heal the earth,[e] so that
not all human beings will perish through all the secret things that the
Watchers revealed and taught their sons. 8 The whole earth has been
ruined by the teaching of the works of Asael; charge all sin to him."

9 To Gabriel the Lord said, "Go against the bastards and the outcasts,
the children of fornication. Destroy the children of the Watchers from
among human beings. Send them against one another, so that they
destroy each other in battle, for they will not have length of days. 10
No request that their fathers make of you for them will be granted,
for they hope to live an everlasting life, and that each of them will
live five hundred years."

11 To Michael the Lord said, "Go, inform Shemihazah[f] and the others
with him who have united themselves with women, so that they
defiled themselves with them in all their uncleanness. 12 When their
sons have killed one another and they have seen the destruction of

their loved ones, bind them for seventy generations under the hills of the earth[g] until the day of their judgment and their end, until the judgment that is forever and ever is completed. 13 In those days they will be led away to the abyss of fire, to the torment, and to the prison where they will be shut up forever. 14 Whoever is condemned and destroyed will from then on be bound together with them until the end of all generations. 15 Wipe out every spirit of the outcasts[h] and of the Watchers' children, for they have done wrong to the human race. 16 Rid the face of the earth of all wrongdoing; put an end to every evil deed, and let the plant of righteousness and truth come into view. It will become a blessing: deeds of righteousness and truth will be planted in truth and joy forever.

17 Then all the righteous will escape,
and they will live until they father thousands,
and all the days of their youth and their old age
they will complete in peace.

18 Then the whole earth will be farmed in righteousness; it will all be planted with trees and be full of blessing.

19 All pleasant trees will be planted on it, and they will plant vines on it. The vine that they plant on it will yield wine in abundance, and of all the seed that is sown on it each measure will yield a thousand, and each measure of olives will yield ten presses of oil.

20 Cleanse the earth from all oppression, from all wrongdoing, from all sin and godlessness; remove from the earth all the uncleanness that is done on it.

21 All human beings will become righteous, and all the nations will worship me and bless me, and all will bow down to me.

22 The earth will be cleansed from all defilement and from all sin, from all punishment and all torment, and I will never again send these upon it, from generation to generation and forever.

Notes

- a (10:1) *Sariel*: so the Greek (*Istraēl*, a corruption); the Ethiopic has *Arsyalalyur*, an unexplained name. See the note at 9:1.
- b (10:1) *Lamech*: Hebrew *Lemekh*, meaning uncertain, perhaps "strong youth." His son is Noah (Gen 5:28–29).

- c (10:2) *Noah*: Hebrew *Noaḥ*, “rest,” linked in Gen 5:29 with *naḥam*, “to comfort.”
- d (10:4) *Dudael*: perhaps “cauldron of God” or “jagged ground of God”; the place cannot be identified. Compare the wilderness of the scapegoat in Lev 16:10, 22.
- e (10:7) That I will heal the earth: so the Greek; the Ethiopic reads “that they may heal the plague.”
- f (10:11) Inform: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has “bind.”
- g (10:12) Under the hills of the earth: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has “in the valleys of the earth.”
- h (10:15) The outcasts: or “the lustful,” the giants; the word is uncertain.

Chapter 11

1 “In those days I will open the storehouses of blessing that are in heaven, to send them down upon the earth, upon the work and labor of human beings. 2 Truth and peace will be joined together through all the days of the world and through all the generations of humankind.”

Chapter 12

1 Before these things Enoch was hidden,[a] and none of the human race knew where he was hidden, where he lived, or what had become of him. 2 He spent all his time with the Watchers, and his days were passed among the holy ones.[b]

3 While I, Enoch, stood blessing the great Lord, the King of the ages, the Watchers summoned me, Enoch the scribe, and told me, 4 “Enoch, scribe of righteousness, go and announce to the Watchers of heaven, who abandoned the high heaven and the holy, everlasting sanctuary, and have defiled themselves with women, and have done as human beings do, and have taken wives for themselves: ‘You have brought great destruction on the earth, 5 and you will have no peace or forgiveness of sin.’ Since they delight in their children, 6 they will see the slaughter of their loved ones and mourn over the destruction of their sons. They will plead forever, but they will obtain neither mercy nor peace.”

Notes

- a (12:1) Was hidden: or “was taken,” echoing Gen 5:24, “he was not, for God took him.”
- b (12:2) The Watchers… the holy ones: here the faithful angels of heaven.

Chapter 13

1 Enoch went and said to Asael, “You will have no peace. A severe
sentence has gone out against you, to bind you. 2 You will have no
relief and no request granted, because of the wrongdoing that you
taught and because of all the works of godlessness, wrongdoing, and
sin that you showed to human beings.”
3 Then I went and spoke to all of them together, and they were
all afraid; fear and trembling seized them. 4 They begged me to
write a petition for them, so that they might find forgiveness, and
to read their petition aloud in the presence of the Lord of heaven.
5 For from that time on they could not speak with him or lift up
their eyes to heaven, out of shame for their sins for which they
had been condemned. 6 So I wrote out their petition and the prayer
concerning their spirits and their deeds one by one, and concerning
their requests, that they might have forgiveness and length of days.
7 I went off and sat down by the waters of Dan,[a] in the land of Dan,
to the southwest of Hermon, and I read their petition aloud until I
fell asleep. 8 And look, a dream came to me, and visions fell upon me.
I saw visions of punishment, and a voice came, telling me to speak
to the sons of heaven and rebuke them. 9 When I woke up, I went to
them. They were all sitting together weeping at Abel-main,[b] which
is between Lebanon and Senir, with their faces covered. 10 I related
to them every vision I had seen while asleep, and I began to speak
words of righteousness and to rebuke the heavenly Watchers.

Notes

- a (13:7) *Dan*: “judge.” The waters of Dan are the springs of the Jordan at Tel Dan, at the foot of Mount Hermon.
- b (13:9) *Abel-main*: “meadow of waters,” probably Abel-beth-maacah near Dan (2 Sam 20:14–15); the Ethiopic has *’Ubelseyāel* and the Greek *Ebelsata*, corruptions of the same name. *Senir*: the Amorite name of Hermon (Deut 3:9).

Chapter 14

1 This book is the word of righteousness and of the rebuke of the
Watchers who are from eternity, according to the command of the
Great Holy One in that vision. 2 In my sleep I saw what I now tell with
a tongue of flesh and the breath of my mouth, which the Great One

gave to humankind for speaking and for understanding in the heart. [3] As he created human beings and gave them the power to understand the word of knowledge, so he created me also and gave me the power to rebuke the Watchers, the sons of heaven. [4] I wrote out your petition, and in my vision it was shown to me that your petition will not be granted to you through all the days of eternity, and that judgment has been passed on you; your request will not be granted. [5] From now on you will not go up into heaven for all eternity. The decree has gone out to bind you in the earth for all the days of the world. [6] Before that, you will see the destruction of your beloved sons; you will have no pleasure in them, but they will fall before you by the sword. [7] Your plea for them will not be granted, nor your plea for yourselves, even if you weep and pray and recite every word of the document I wrote. [8] The vision was shown to me in this way. Look, in the vision clouds called me, and mist summoned me; the course of the stars and the lightning hurried me along and drove me on, and the winds in the vision made me fly, lifted me upward, and carried me into heaven. [9] I went in until I came near a wall built of hailstones[a] and surrounded by tongues of fire, and it began to frighten me. [10] I went into the tongues of fire and came near a great house built of hailstones. The walls of the house were like a mosaic floor of hailstones, and its floor was of snow.[b] [11] Its ceiling was like the path of the stars and the lightning, and among them were fiery cherubim,[c] and their sky was water. [12] Flaming fire surrounded the walls, and its doors blazed with fire. [13] I entered that house. It was hot as fire and cold as snow, and there was nothing of the pleasures of life in it. Fear covered me, and trembling took hold of me. [14] As I was shaking and trembling, I fell on my face. And I saw in the vision, [15] and look, there was a second house, greater than the first. Its whole doorway stood open before me, and it was built of tongues of fire. [16] In every respect it so surpassed the first in splendor, magnificence, and size that I cannot describe to you its splendor and its size. [17] Its floor was of fire; above it were lightning and the path of the stars, and its ceiling too was blazing fire. [18] I looked and saw in it a lofty throne. Its appearance was like frost,[d] and its wheels were like the shining sun, and there was the sound[e] of cherubim. [19]

From beneath the throne came out rivers of blazing fire, so that I could not look at it.[f] 20 The Great Glory was seated on it. His robe was brighter than the sun and whiter than any snow. 21 None of the angels could enter that house or look at his face because of its majesty and glory, and no flesh could look at him. 22 Flaming fire encircled him, a great fire burned in front of him, and no one around him could come near him. Myriads upon myriads stood in his presence, yet he needed no counselor.[g] 23 The holiest ones who were near him did not leave by night or depart from him. 24 All this while I had lain face down, trembling. Then the Lord himself called me, speaking with his own mouth: "Come here, Enoch, and hear my word." 25 One of the holy ones came to me and roused me; he made me get up and come to the door, and I bowed my face downward.

Notes

- a (14:9) Hailstones: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "crystals."
- b (14:10) Its floor was of snow: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "its foundation was of crystal."
- c (14:11) Cherubim: Hebrew plural of *kerub*, winged heavenly beings who guard God's throne (Exod 25:18–22; Ezek 1; 10).
- d (14:18) Frost: or "ice" (Greek *krystallinon*, "ice-like").
- e (14:18) The sound: so the Greek, reading *phōnē*, "voice"; the Ethiopic has "vision."
- f (14:19) Compare Dan 7:9–10; Ezek 1:26–28.
- g (14:22) He needed no counselor: so the Greek, "every word of his is deed"; the Ethiopic reads "and he needs no holy counsel."

Chapter 15

1 He answered and said to me, and I heard his voice, "Do not be afraid, Enoch, righteous man and scribe of righteousness. Come here and hear my voice. 2 Go and say to the Watchers of heaven who sent you to intercede for them: 'You ought to intercede for human beings, not human beings for you. 3 Why have you left the high, holy, and eternal heaven, lain with women, defiled yourselves with the daughters of men, taken wives for yourselves, and acted like the children of earth, and fathered giants as your sons? 4 Though you were holy and spiritual, living eternal life, you defiled yourselves with the blood of women; you fathered children with the blood of flesh, and like

human beings you longed for flesh and blood, as those who die and perish do. 5 That is why I gave them wives, so that they might make them pregnant and have children by them, so that nothing would be lacking to them on the earth. 6 But you were formerly spiritual, living eternal life, immortal for all the generations of the world. 7 Therefore I did not appoint wives for you, for the spiritual beings of heaven have their dwelling in heaven.

8 But now the giants, who were born from spirit and flesh, will be called evil spirits on the earth, and their dwelling will be on the earth. 9 Evil spirits have come out of their bodies, because they were created from above;[a] their beginning and first origin is from the holy Watchers. They will be evil spirits on the earth, and they will be called evil spirits. 10 The spirits of heaven have their dwelling in heaven, but the spirits of the earth, which were born on the earth, will have their dwelling on the earth.[b] 11 The spirits of the giants oppress, destroy, attack, wage war, and crush on the earth, and they cause sorrow. They eat no food, yet they hunger and thirst, and they cause offenses.[c] 12 These spirits will rise up against human beings and against women, because they came out from them.

Notes

- a (15:9) Because they were created from above: so the Greek; the Ethiopic reads "because they were born from men."
- b (15:10) Charles regarded this verse as an addition, since it repeats verses 7–8.
- c (15:11) They hunger and thirst: so the Ethiopic. The Greek is obscure and is sometimes taken to mean that they do not hunger, but cause illnesses.

Chapter 16

1 "'From the day of the slaughter and destruction and death of the giants, the spirits that have gone out from their bodies[a] will destroy without facing judgment. In this way they will destroy until the day of the completion, the great judgment, in which the great age will be completed upon the Watchers and the godless; it will be wholly completed.' 2 And now say to the Watchers who sent you to intercede for them, who were formerly in heaven, 3 'You were in heaven, but not all the mysteries had been revealed to you. You knew a worthless mystery,[b] and in the hardness of your hearts you made it known to the

women, and through this mystery women and men are doing much evil on the earth.' [4] So say to them, 'You have no peace.'"

Notes

- a (16:1) From their bodies: literally "from the souls of their flesh."
- b (16:3) A worthless mystery: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "rejected mysteries."

Chapter 17

[1] They took me and brought me to a place where those who were there looked like blazing fire, and whenever they wished, they took on the appearance of men. [2] They led me to the place of storm[a] and to a mountain whose highest peak reached into heaven. [3] I saw the places of the lights, the storehouses of the stars and of the thunder, and in the farthest depths a bow of fire, arrows with their quiver, a sword of fire, and all the lightning flashes. [4] They brought me to the waters of life,[b] and to the fire of the west, where the sun goes down each evening. [5] I came to a river of fire whose fire flows like water and pours out into the great sea in the west. [6] I viewed the great rivers; I reached the great river and the great darkness and went on to where no living creature walks. [7] I saw the mountains of the winter darkness and the place from which the water of every abyss pours out. [8] Every river on earth, I saw where it emptied, and where the abyss opens.

Notes

- a (17:2) Storm: so the Greek (*zophōdē*, "gloomy, stormy"); the Ethiopic has "darkness."
- b (17:4) The waters of life: literally "living waters," that is, running water; here perhaps the waters at the edge of the world.

Chapter 18

[1] I saw the storerooms of all the winds, and I saw how with them he has adorned the whole creation, and the foundations of the earth. [2] I saw the cornerstone of the earth. I saw the four winds that hold up the earth and the vault of the sky. [3] I saw how the winds spread out the height of heaven and stand between heaven and earth; they are the pillars of the sky. [4] I saw the winds of heaven that turn and lead the circle of the sun and all the stars to their setting. [5] I saw the earthly

winds bearing the clouds along, and the roads the angels travel, and, at the earth's edge, the sky's vault overhead.
6 I went on toward the south[a] and saw a place burning day and night, where there were seven mountains of precious stones, three toward the east and three toward the south. 7 Of those toward the east, one was of colored stone, one of pearl, and one of healing stone;[b] those toward the south were of red stone. 8 The middle one reached to heaven like the throne of God; it was of antimony,[c] and the top of the throne was of sapphire. 9 I saw a blazing fire. Beyond these mountains 10 lies a region where the great earth stops and the heavens are finished. 11 I saw a great chasm among pillars of heavenly fire, and I saw in it pillars of fire falling, beyond measure both in height and in depth. 12 Beyond that chasm I saw a place that had no vault of heaven above it and no solid ground beneath it. There was no water on it and no birds; it was a desolate and dreadful place. 13 Seven stars were there, like huge mountains on fire. When I inquired about them, 14 the angel told me, "Here heaven and earth come to their limit. This place now serves as a jail for the stars and the heavenly host. 15 The stars that roll over the fire are those that disobeyed the command of the Lord at the beginning of their rising, because they did not come out at their proper times. 16 He was angry with them and bound them until the time when their sin is completed, for ten thousand years."[d]

Notes

- a (18:6) Toward the south: so the Greek; the Ethiopic lacks the direction.
- b (18:7) Healing stone: so the Greek (*iaseōs*); the Ethiopic has "jacinth" or "antimony." The identification of these stones is uncertain.
- c (18:8) Antimony: so the Ethiopic; the Greek has *phouka*, perhaps a dark stone. Compare the sapphire of the divine throne in Exod 24:10 and Ezek 1:26.
- d (18:16) Ten thousand years: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "in the year of the mystery."

Chapter 19

1 Sariel[a] said to me, "Here will stand the angels who mixed with women. Their spirits, taking many forms, defile humankind and lead people astray into sacrificing to demons as to gods. Here they will stand until the day of the great judgment, when they will be judged

until they are finished. 2 Their women, the wives of the angels who went astray, will become sirens."[b] 3 I, Enoch, alone saw the sight, the ends of all things, and no human being will see what I have seen.

Notes

- a (19:1) *Sariel*: "prince of God"; so the Aramaic and Greek here, reportedly; the Ethiopic has *Uriel*. Compare 9:1.
- b (19:2) Sirens: so the Greek (*seirēnas*); in the Greek Old Testament the word renders desert creatures (Isa 13:21). The Ethiopic reads "will become peaceful," a misreading of the Greek.

Chapter 20

1 Here are the names of the holy angels who stand watch: 2 Uriel,[a] one of the holy angels, in charge of the world and of Tartarus.[b] 3 Raphael, a holy angel, in charge of human spirits. 4 Raguel, a holy angel, who brings punishment on the world of the lights. 5 Michael, a holy angel, placed in charge of the finest of humankind, the people.[c] 6 Saraqael, a holy angel, in charge of the spirits of those who sin in spirit. 7 Gabriel, a holy angel, in charge of Paradise, the serpents, and the cherubim. 8 Remiel, a holy angel, whom God put in charge of those who rise.[d]

Notes

- a (20:2) *Uriel*: "God is my light." For the other names see the note at 9:1. *Raguel*: "friend of God." *Saraqael* (Greek *Sariēl*): perhaps "God has struck" or "prince of God." *Remiel*: "God has raised up" or "mercy of God."
- b (20:2) Tartarus: in Greek thought the deepest part of the underworld, where rebel powers are imprisoned; compare 2 Pet 2:4. The Ethiopic has "thunder and trembling."
- c (20:5) Over the people: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "over chaos." Michael is the guardian of Israel (Dan 10:21; 12:1).
- d (20:8) Verse 8 is found only in one Greek copy, which also gives the total as seven archangels.

Chapter 21

1 I traveled on to where there was nothing made.[a] 2 There I saw something dreadful: I saw neither a heaven above nor solid ground below, but a desolate and fearful place. 3 In it seven heavenly stars lay tied together, burning, as large as great mountains. 4 Then I asked, "For what sin have they been bound, and why have they been thrown here?" 5 Uriel, a holy angel who accompanied me and who led them,

replied, “Enoch, what is your question for, and why are you so eager for the truth? 6 These are some of the stars of heaven that disobeyed the command of the Lord. They have been bound here until ten thousand years are completed, the time required by their sins.”
7 From there I went to another place, more dreadful than the first. I saw a terrible thing there: a great fire burning and blazing. The place had a cleft reaching down to the abyss, full of great columns of fire falling downward. I could not see its size or its extent, nor could I estimate it. 8 Then I said, “How frightening this place is, and how terrible to look at!” 9 Uriel, one of the holy angels who was with me, answered, “Enoch, why are you so afraid and terrified?” I answered, “Because of this frightening place and this sight of pain.” 10 He said to me, “This place is the prison of the angels. They will be held here forever.”

Notes

- a (21:1) Where there was nothing made: or “to the place of chaos”; literally “to the formless.”

Chapter 22

1 Next I traveled to another place, where he pointed out to me in the west a great, high mountain and a hard rock.[a] 2 In it were four hollow places, deep and very smooth: three of them were dark and one was bright, with a spring of water in the middle of it.[b] I said, “How smooth these hollows are, how deep and dark to look at!” 3 Raphael, a holy angel who accompanied me, replied, “These hollows were made for exactly this: that the spirits of the souls of the dead might gather in them. They were made so that all the souls of human beings might gather here. 4 These places were made to hold them until the day of their judgment and until their appointed time, until the great judgment comes upon them.”
5 I saw the spirit of a dead man pleading, and its voice went out to heaven, making its case.[c] 6 I asked Raphael, the angel who was with me, “Whose spirit is this, whose voice goes up to heaven making its plea?” 7 He answered me, “This is the spirit that came out of Abel,[d] whom his brother Cain killed. He goes on accusing him until his

offspring is destroyed from the face of the earth and his descendants have disappeared from the descendants of humankind."
8 Then I asked about all the hollows: "Why is each one separated from the others?" 9 He answered me, "These three[e] were made to separate the spirits of the dead. This one has been set apart for the spirits of the righteous, where the bright spring of water is. 10 This one is for sinners who die and are laid in the ground without having been judged while they lived. 11 Here their spirits are kept apart in this great pain until the great day of judgment, of punishment, and of torment for those who curse forever, and of vengeance on their spirits. There he will bind them forever. 12 This one has been set apart for the spirits of those who make accusation, who disclose how they were destroyed, when they were murdered in the days of the sinners. 13 This one was made for the spirits of people who were not godly but sinners, complete in lawlessness, who will be companions of the lawless. Their spirits will not be punished on the day of judgment, nor will they be raised from here." 14 Then I blessed the Lord of glory and said, "Blessed are you, Lord, the righteous Judge, who rules forever."[f]

Notes

- a (22:1) A great, high mountain and a hard rock: so the Greek; the Ethiopic reads "a great and high mountain of hard rock."
- b (22:2) Three of them were dark… in the middle of it: so the Greek; the Ethiopic lacks these words. An Aramaic fragment (4QEn[e]) is reported to read "deep and wide."
- c (22:5) So the Greek; the Ethiopic reads "I saw the spirits of the sons of men who were dead."
- d (22:7) *Abel*: Hebrew *Hevel*, "breath" or "vapor." *Cain*: Hebrew *Qayin*, connected in Gen 4:1 with *qanah*, "to acquire." Compare Gen 4:10, "Your brother's blood cries out to me from the ground," and Heb 12:24.
- e (22:9) These three: some take this to mean "these"; four places are described in verses 9–13.
- f (22:14) So the Greek, approximately; the Ethiopic reads "Blessed be my Lord, the Lord of righteousness, who rules forever."

Chapter 23

1 From there I went to another place, to the west, at the ends of the earth. 2 I saw a fire blazing and running without rest; it did not stop

its course day or night but kept on in the same way. 3 I asked, "What is this that never rests?" 4 Raguel, a holy angel who accompanied me, replied, "This running fire before you is the fire in the west that drives on all the lights of heaven."

Chapter 24

1 From there I went to another place on the earth, and he showed me a range of mountains of fire that burned day and night. 2 I went beyond it and saw seven splendid mountains, each different from the others. Their stones were precious and beautiful, the whole range splendid, glorious to look at and lovely in form: three toward the east, set firmly one on another, and three toward the south, one on another, with deep, winding ravines, none of which joined any other. 3 The seventh mountain stood in the middle of them and rose above them in height, like the seat of a throne, and fragrant trees surrounded the throne. 4 Among them was a tree whose like I had never smelled; neither among these nor among others was there one like it. It had a fragrance beyond every fragrance, and its leaves, its blossoms, and its wood never wither. Its fruit is beautiful and is like the clusters of a date palm. 5 Then I said, "What a beautiful tree this is, and how fragrant! Its leaves are lovely, and its blossoms are a delight to the eye." 6 Then Michael, one of the holy and honored angels, who was with me and was their leader, answered me.

Chapter 25

1 He said to me, "Enoch, why do you ask me about the fragrance of the tree, and why do you want to learn the truth?"

2 I replied, "I wish to understand all things, and this tree above all."

3 He replied, "This lofty mountain before you, whose peak resembles God's throne, really is his throne, where the Great Holy One, the Lord of glory, the King of eternity, will sit when he comes down to visit the earth with goodness.

4 As for this fragrant tree, no flesh has authority to touch it until the great judgment, when he will take vengeance on all and bring every-

thing to its completion forever. Then it will be given to the righteous and the humble.

5 Its fruit will be food for the chosen. It will be moved to the holy place, to the house of the Lord, the King of eternity.[a]

6 Then they will rejoice greatly and be glad,
and they will enter the holy place.
Its fragrance will be in their bones,
and they will live a long life on the earth,
as your ancestors lived;
in their days no sorrow or pain,
no toil or affliction will touch them."

7 Then I blessed the God of glory, the King of eternity, who has prepared such things for the righteous, has created them, and has promised to give them to them.

Notes

- a (25:5) Moved to the holy place: probably Jerusalem, described in chapter 26. The tree recalls the tree of life (Gen 2:9; 3:22; Rev 22:2, 14).

Chapter 26

1 From there I went to the center of the earth and saw a blessed place with trees whose branches were alive and sprouting from a tree that had been cut down.[a] 2 There I saw a holy mountain,[b] and beneath the mountain, to its east, there was water,[c] and it flowed toward the south. 3 I saw toward the east another mountain higher than this one, and between them a deep, narrow ravine; a stream ran through it, at the foot of the mountain. 4 To the west of it was another mountain, lower than it and not high, and between them a deep, dry ravine; and another deep, dry ravine lay at the far end of the three mountains. 5 All the ravines were deep and narrow, of hard rock, and no trees were planted in them. 6 I was amazed at the rock, and amazed at the ravine; I was very much amazed.

Notes

- a (26:1) The center of the earth: Jerusalem (compare Ezek 38:12; Jubilees 8:19). The cut tree that sprouts may allude to Israel's restoration (compare Isa 11:1).
- b (26:2) A holy mountain: Mount Zion. The mountain to the east is the Mount of Olives; the stream is the spring of Gihon and the Kidron; the lower mountain to

the west is perhaps the Hill of Evil Counsel or the western hill; the deep ravines are the Kidron and Hinnom valleys.
- c (26:2) Water: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "a stream."

Chapter 27

1 Then I said, "Why is this land blessed and wholly filled with trees, while this ravine between is cursed?" 2 Then Sariel,[a] one of the holy angels who was with me, answered, "This cursed valley is for those who are cursed forever. Here all those will be gathered who speak improper words against the Lord with their mouths and say harsh things about his glory. Here they will be gathered, and here will be their place of judgment.[b] 3 In the last days there will be the spectacle of a righteous judgment upon them in the presence of the righteous forever. Here those who have found mercy will bless the Lord of glory, the King of eternity. 4 In the days of their judgment[c] they will bless him for the mercy he has shown them, for he has assigned them their lot." 5 Then I blessed the Lord of glory; I proclaimed his glory and praised him as befits his majesty.

Notes
- a (27:2) *Sariel*: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has *Uriel*. See the notes at 9:1 and 19:1.
- b (27:2) This cursed valley: the Valley of Hinnom (Gehenna), south of Jerusalem, a place of child sacrifice under the kings (Jer 7:31–32) and later an image of final punishment (Isa 66:24; Mark 9:43–48).
- c (27:4) Their judgment: the judgment of the wicked.

Chapter 28

1 From there I went eastward into the middle of the mountain range of the wilderness, and I saw desert land, lonely, but full of trees and plants.[a] 2 Water gushed out from above. 3 It streamed like an abundant watercourse flowing toward the northwest, and from every side it sent up water and dew.[b]

Notes
- a (28:1) But full of trees and plants: so the Greek; the Ethiopic places the trees after the water of verse 2.
- b (28:3) Water and dew: so the Greek; the Ethiopic has "clouds and dew."

Chapter 29

1 From there I went to another place in the wilderness, to the east
of this mountain range, and came near it. 2 There I saw trees of
judgment,[a] breathing out the fragrance of frankincense and myrrh,
and the trees were not like ordinary trees.[b]

Notes

- a (29:2) Trees of judgment: so the Ethiopic, perhaps a corruption; the Greek has "aromatic trees."
- b (29:2) Not like ordinary trees: so the Greek, approximately; the Ethiopic has "similar to the almond tree."

Chapter 30

1 Past these I journeyed a long way east and came upon another place,
a well-watered valley, 2 with a tree in it the color of fragrant trees, like
the mastic.[a] 3 Fragrant cinnamon grew along the valley slopes. Past
them I continued east.

Notes

- a (30:2) Mastic: an aromatic resin from the mastic tree (*Pistacia lentiscus*). The Greek here is uncertain.

Chapter 31

1 I saw other mountains, and on them were trees from which flowed
nectar called *sarara* and galbanum.[a] 2 Beyond these mountains I
saw another mountain, and on it were aloe trees,[b] all full of stacte,
like almond trees. 3 When one burns it, it smells sweeter than any
perfume.

Notes

- a (31:1) *Sarara*: an aromatic not otherwise known, perhaps storax. Galbanum is a fragrant gum resin used in the incense of the tabernacle (Exod 30:34).
- b (31:2) Aloe trees: aloeswood, a fragrant wood; compare Ps 45:8; Prov 7:17. *Stacte*: a fragrant resin (Exod 30:34), perhaps from storax or myrrh.

Chapter 32

1 Leaving these fragrances behind, as I gazed northward[a] over the
mountains, I saw seven mountains full of choice nard, fragrant trees,
cinnamon, and pepper. 2 From there I passed over the summits of
all those mountains, far to the east of the earth. I crossed above the

Red Sea[b] and went far beyond it, and I passed over the darkness,[c] far from it. 3 I came to the Garden of Righteousness. From far off I saw trees more numerous and greater than these, of fine fragrance, very beautiful and glorious, and the tree of wisdom, whose fruit the holy ones eat and gain great wisdom. 4 That tree is as tall as a fir; its leaves are like those of the carob, and its fruit is like a cluster of grapes, very beautiful. Its fragrance spreads far beyond the tree. 5 Then I said, "How beautiful this tree is, and how pleasing to look at!" 6 Raphael, the holy angel accompanying me, replied, "That is the tree of wisdom. Your father and mother of old, who lived long before you, ate from it; they gained wisdom, their eyes were opened, they realized they were naked, and they were expelled from the garden."[d]

Notes

- a (32:1) Toward the north: the Greek has "toward the northeast."
- b (32:2) The Red Sea: so the Greek (*Erythra thalassa*), which in ancient usage included the Indian Ocean and the Persian Gulf.
- c (32:2) The darkness: so the Greek (*zotiēl* is read as a corruption of *zophos*, "darkness"); the Ethiopic reads "the angel Zotiel."
- d (32:6) Your aged father and your aged mother: Adam and Eve. *Adam*: Hebrew *'adam*, "human being," connected with *'adamah*, "ground" (Gen 2:7). *Eve*: Hebrew *Ḥawwah*, connected with *ḥay*, "living" (Gen 3:20). Compare Gen 3:6–7, 23–24.

Chapter 33

1 From there I went to the ends of the earth and saw great animals there, each different from the others, and also birds different in appearance, beauty, and voice, each from the other. 2 East of those animals I saw the ends of the earth on which heaven rests, and the gates of heaven open. 3 I watched the heavenly stars emerge; I counted the gates they emerge from and recorded every exit, star by star: how many, what each is called, its route, its station, its seasons, and its months, just as Uriel, the holy angel at my side, pointed them out. 4 He showed me everything and wrote it down for me. He also wrote down their names for me, and their laws and their functions.

Chapter 34

1 Then I traveled north to the earth's farthest reaches, and at the edge
of the whole world I beheld a great and splendid marvel. 2 Three
heavenly gates stood open in the sky there, and north winds issue
from each; their blowing brings cold and hail, frost and snow, dew
and rain. 3 Through one gate they blow to bring benefit; through the
other two they blow violently and bring hardship on the earth.

Chapter 35

1 From there I went westward to the ends of the earth, and there I saw
three gates of heaven open, just as I had seen in the east: the same
number of gates and the same number of exits.

Chapter 36

1 From there I went southward to the ends of the earth, and there
I saw three open gates of heaven, from which come dew, rain, and
wind. 2 From there I went eastward to the ends of heaven, and there
I saw the three eastern gates of heaven open, with small gates above
them. 3 Through each of these small gates the stars of heaven pass
and run their course westward on the path that has been shown to
them. 4 Each time I saw these things I praised the Lord of glory, and I
keep praising the Lord of glory, who has worked great and glorious
wonders so that angels, spirits, and mortals may behold how great
his work is, may praise what he has made and all his creatures, may
witness what his power does, may extol the mighty work of his hands,
and may bless him forever.

Chapter 37

The Book of Discourses (Parables) (chapters 37–71)

1 The second vision that he saw, a vision of wisdom, which Enoch saw,
son of Jared, son of Mahalalel, son of Kenan, son of Enosh, son of Seth,
son of Adam.[a] 2 This is how the words of wisdom begin, which I raised
my voice to speak and declare to those who live on the dry ground:
Listen, you people of former times, and look, you who come later, at
the words of the Holy One that I will speak before the Lord of Spirits.[b]
3 It would have been fitting to tell these things to the ancients alone,

but we will not keep the beginning of wisdom back from those who come after either. [4] Never until now has the Lord of Spirits granted such wisdom as I have received, in keeping with my understanding and by the will of the Lord of Spirits, who has given me a share in everlasting life. [5] Three discourses[c] were given to me, and I raised my voice and told them to those who live on the dry ground.

Notes

- a (37:1) *Mahalalel*: "praise of God." *Kenan* (Ethiopic *Qāynān*): perhaps "smith" or "possession." *Enosh*: "human being, mortal." *Seth*: "appointed" or "granted" (Gen 4:25). The genealogy follows Gen 5:3–18. "The second vision" counts the Book of the Watchers (chapters 1–36) as the first. This section, called "the Parables" or "Similitudes," survives only in Ge'ez; no Aramaic or Greek fragment of it has been found. Its date is debated, with most recent scholars placing it in the late first century BC or the first century AD.
- b (37:2) The Lord of Spirits: the standard title for God in chapters 37–71, used over a hundred times; compare "the God of the spirits of all flesh" in Num 16:22; 27:16, and "Yahweh of hosts" in the Hebrew Bible, which it may echo.
- c (37:5) Discourses: Ge'ez *mesālē*, like Hebrew *mashal*, "parable, proverb, figurative speech, oracle" (compare Num 23:7). The three are chapters 38–44, 45–57, and 58–69.

Chapter 38

[1] The first discourse.

When the community of the righteous appears,
and sinners are judged for their sins
and driven from the face of the dry ground;

[2] when the Righteous One[a] appears in the sight of the righteous,
whose chosen deeds depend on the Lord of Spirits,
and light shines on the righteous and the chosen who live on the dry ground—
where then will the sinners live,
and where will those who denied the Lord of Spirits find rest?
It would have been better for them never to have been born.[b]

[3] When the secrets of the righteous are disclosed,
the sinners are judged,
and the wicked are driven out from the presence of the righteous and the chosen,

4 from then on those who hold the land will no longer be mighty and lofty;
they will not be able to look at the face of the holy ones,
for the Lord of Spirits will have made his light appear
on the faces of the holy, the righteous, and the chosen.
5 Then the kings and the powerful will perish,
handed over to the righteous and the holy.
6 From then on no one will plead for mercy for them from the Lord of Spirits,
for their life will be over.

Notes

- a (38:2) The Righteous One: one of four titles in the Parables for the heavenly figure who judges at the end: "the Righteous One," "the Chosen One," "the Anointed One" (48:10; 52:4), and "that Son of Man." Some manuscripts read "righteousness" here.
- b (38:2) Compare Matt 26:24; Mark 14:21.

Chapter 39

1 In those days chosen and holy children will come down from the high heaven, and their offspring will be joined with the children of humankind.[a]
2 In those days Enoch received books of jealous anger and fury, books of turmoil and banishment.
"No mercy will be granted to them," says the Lord of Spirits.
3 In those days a whirlwind[b] snatched me up from the earth
and put me down at the far end of the heavens.
4 There I saw another vision:
the homes of the holy ones
and the resting places of the righteous.
5 There my eyes beheld their homes among his righteous angels,
their resting places among the holy ones.
They were petitioning, pleading, and praying for the children of humankind;
righteousness flowed before them like water,
and mercy like dew on the ground.
So it is among them forever and ever.

6 In those days[c] my eyes saw the Chosen One of righteousness and faithfulness.

Righteousness will prevail in his days,

and the righteous and chosen will be beyond number before him forever and ever.

7 I saw his home under the wings of the Lord of Spirits.

All the righteous and chosen before him will shine like flames of fire;

their mouths will be full of blessing,

their lips will praise the name of the Lord of Spirits,

and righteousness will never fail before him,

nor will truth fail in his presence.

8 There I longed to live;

my spirit yearned for that home.

That is where my share has been from the start,

for so it was settled for me before the Lord of Spirits.

9 In those days I praised and exalted the name of the Lord of Spirits with blessing and praise, for he has destined me for blessing and glory by the good pleasure of the Lord of Spirits.

10 For a long time my eyes gazed at that place, and I gave him blessing and praise: "Blessed be he! From the beginning and for all time to come may he be blessed!

11 In his presence nothing ends. He knew before the world was made what the age is and what will be from generation to generation.

12 Those who never sleep bless you. They stand before your glory and bless, praise, and exalt you, saying:

'Holy, holy, holy is the Lord of Spirits;

he fills the earth with spirits.' "[d]

13 There my eyes saw all who never sleep, standing before him and blessing him and saying, "Blessed are you, and blessed is the name of the Lord forever and ever."

14 My face was transformed, for I could no longer bear to look.

Notes

- a (39:1) Verses 1–2a seem to refer back to the Watchers (chapters 6–16), and some take them as an insertion.

- b (39:3) A whirlwind: or "a cloud and a storm." Compare Elijah in 2 Kgs 2:11.
- c (39:6) In those days: Charles transposes parts of verses 6 and 7; this translation keeps the order of the manuscripts.
- d (39:12) Compare Isa 6:3, "Holy, holy, holy is Yahweh of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory." "Those who never sleep" are the Watchers (compare 14:23).

Chapter 40

1 After that I saw thousands upon thousands and myriads upon myriads, a throng past all counting and reckoning, standing before the Lord of Spirits.[a] 2 Around the Lord of Spirits, one on each of his four sides, stood four figures,[b] different from those who do not sleep, and I learned their names, since the angel accompanying me told me what they were called and showed me every hidden thing. 3 I heard the voices of those four figures as they spoke praises before the Lord of glory. 4 The first voice was blessing the Lord of Spirits forever and ever. 5 The second voice I heard blessing the Chosen One and the chosen ones who depend on the Lord of Spirits. 6 The third voice I heard praying and pleading for those who live on the dry ground and who call on the name of the Lord of Spirits. 7 The fourth voice I heard driving away the satans[c] and barring them from approaching the Lord of Spirits with accusations against those who live on the dry ground.

8 Then I put a question to the angel of peace, my companion, who had and showed me everything hidden, "Who are these four figures whom I have seen, whose words I have heard and written down?" 9 He told me, "The first is Michael, merciful and slow to anger. The second, who is set over every disease and every wound of humankind, is Raphael. The third, who is set over every power, is Gabriel. And the fourth, who is set over repentance and the hope of those who will inherit everlasting life, is named Phanuel."[d] 10 Those were the Lord of Spirits' four angels, and theirs were the four voices I heard in those days.

Notes

- a (40:1) Compare Dan 7:10.
- b (40:2) Figures: literally "faces" or "presences," the angels of the presence (compare Isa 63:9).

- c (40:7) Satans: “accusers, adversaries” (Hebrew *satan*), here a class of hostile angels who accuse human beings before God; compare Job 1:6–12; Zech 3:1; Rev 12:10.
- d (40:9) *Michael*: “Who is like God?” *Raphael*: “God heals.” *Gabriel*: “God is my strength” or “man of God.” *Phanuel*: “face of God” (compare Penuel, Gen 32:30). Phanuel takes the place of Uriel in the list of four at 9:1.

Chapter 41

1 After that I saw all the secrets of heaven, how the kingdom is divided
up, and how human deeds are weighed on the scales. 2 There I saw
the homes of the chosen and the homes of the holy ones. My eyes
saw there all the sinners who deny the name of the Lord of Spirits
being driven out and dragged away; they could not stay, because of
the punishment that goes out from the Lord of Spirits.
3 There my eyes saw the secrets of the lightning and the thunder, the
secrets of the winds, how they are portioned out to blow across the
land, and what is hidden in cloud and dew. I saw there where they
come from in that place, and from where they soak the dusty ground.
4 There I saw sealed storerooms from which the winds are portioned
out: the storeroom of the hail, the storeroom of the mist, and the
storeroom of the clouds, whose cloud has hovered over the earth
since the world began.
5 I saw the chambers of the sun and the moon, from where they
come out and where they return, their glorious going back, how one
outranks the other, their majestic circuit, how they never leave their
track, neither adding to it nor taking from it, and how they keep faith
with each other by the oath that binds them.
6 First the sun goes out and travels its road at the command of the
Lord of Spirits, whose name is mighty forever and ever.
7 Next I saw the moon’s path, both its hidden and its visible part. She
completes the course of her path there by day and by night, each
facing the other before the Lord of Spirits.

They give thanks and praise and never rest,
for their thanksgiving is their rest.

8 For the bright sun makes many turnings, for blessing or for curse,
and the course of the moon’s path

brings light for the righteous
and darkness for sinners, by the name of the Lord,
who separated light from darkness,
divided the spirits of humankind,
and strengthened the spirits of the just
through his righteous name.
9 No angel can stand in the way, nor can any power prevent it; he appoints one to judge them all, and that judge tries them all in his presence.

Chapter 42

1 Wisdom found no place to live,
so a home was given her in the heavens.
2 Wisdom went out to make her home among human beings,
but found no home;
so Wisdom went back to her place
and took her seat among the angels.[a]
3 Then Wrongdoing came out of her storerooms;
she found those she was not looking for,
and she lived among them,
like rain in a desert,
like dew on a thirsty land.

Notes

- a (42:2) Compare Prov 1:20–33; 8; Sir 24:1–12, where Wisdom finds a home in Israel; and John 1:10–11.

Chapter 43

1 Then I saw more lightning and the heavenly stars; he summoned each of them by name, and they listened to him. 2 I saw how they are weighed on a just scale according to their brightness: the breadth of their spaces and the day they appear, how their circling produces lightning, how their circling matches the number of the angels, and how they stay loyal to each other. 3 I asked the angel who went with me and showed me what was hidden, "What are these?" 4 He said to me, "The Lord of Spirits has shown you their meaning in a figure:

these are the names of the holy ones who live on the dry ground and believe in the name of the Lord of Spirits forever and ever."

Chapter 44

1 I saw another thing concerning the lightning: how some of the stars rise and become lightning flashes and cannot give up their new form.

Chapter 45

1 This is the second discourse, concerning those who reject the name of the holy ones' dwelling and of the Lord of Spirits.

2 They will not go up into heaven,
nor will they come back upon the earth.
That is the fate awaiting sinners
who rejected the Lord of Spirits' name,
held in this state for the day of suffering and distress.

3 On that day my Chosen One will sit on the throne of glory,
and will choose among their deeds,[a]
and their resting places will be past counting;
their spirits will grow strong within them when they see my chosen ones
and those who have called on my holy and glorious name.

4 Then I will make my Chosen One live among them;
I will transform heaven
and make it an everlasting blessing and light.

5 I will transform the dry ground and make it a blessing,
and I will make my chosen ones live on it;
but sinners and evildoers will not set foot on it.[b]

6 For I have looked after my righteous ones and satisfied them with peace,
and placed them before me;
but for the sinners judgment waits with me,
to wipe them from the face of the earth.

Notes

- a (45:3) Choose among their deeds: or "test their deeds."
- b (45:5) Compare Isa 65:17; 66:22; 2 Pet 3:13; Rev 21:1.

Chapter 46

1 There I beheld one with a head of days,[a]
his head as white as wool,
and beside him a second, whose face had a human look,
and his face was full of grace, like one of the holy angels.
2 I questioned the angel accompanying me, who was revealing every secret to me, about that Son of Man:[b] who he was, where he came from, and why he was accompanying the Head of Days.
3 He answered me,
"This is the Son of Man who has righteousness,
with whom righteousness lives,
who will reveal all the treasures of what is hidden;
for the Lord of Spirits has chosen him,
and his lot has prevailed before the Lord of Spirits in uprightness forever.
4 This Son of Man whom you have seen
will rouse the kings and the powerful from their couches
and the strong from their thrones;
he will slacken the grip of the strong
and smash the teeth of sinners.
5 He will throw the kings down from their thrones and their kingdoms,
because they do not exalt and praise him
or humbly acknowledge where their kingship came from.
6 He will make the faces of the strong fall,
and shame will fill them.
Darkness will be their home,
and worms their bed;
they will have no hope of getting up from those beds,
since they refuse to exalt the name of the Lord of Spirits.
7 These are the ones who judge the stars of heaven,[c]
who raise their hands against the Most High,
who tread the dry ground and live on it.
All their deeds show wrongdoing,
and their deeds are wrongdoing;[d]

their strength rests on their wealth,
and their trust is in the gods their own hands have made;
they deny the name of the Lord of Spirits.
8 They hound the houses where his people gather
and the faithful who rely on the name of the Lord of Spirits.

Notes

- a (46:1) A head of days: that is, one who is very old; God, called "the Ancient of Days" in Dan 7:9, 13, 22. This chapter draws on Dan 7:9–14.
- b (46:2) That Son of Man: in Ge'ez *walda sab'*; elsewhere in the Parables also *walda be'si* and *walda ʿegwala ʿemma-ḥeyāw*, all meaning "son of a human being," that is, "a human figure," as in Dan 7:13. The demonstrative ("that," "this") points back to the figure first seen here. Compare the Gospels' use of "the Son of Man."
- c (46:7) Judge the stars of heaven: perhaps "attack the stars," that is, the holy ones; compare Dan 8:10. Some propose "raise their hands against the stars."
- d (46:7) Their deeds are wrongdoing: so some manuscripts; others read "their power rests on their wealth."

Chapter 47

1 In those days the prayer of the righteous will have gone up,
and the righteous blood from the ground, into the presence of the Lord of Spirits.
2 In those days the holy ones who live in the heavens above
will join with one voice
to plead and pray, praise, give thanks, and bless the Lord of Spirits' name
because of the blood of the righteous that has been shed,
that the righteous may not have prayed in vain before the Lord of Spirits,
that justice may be done for them,
and that their waiting may not go on forever.[a]
3 In those days I watched the Head of Days sit down on his glorious throne;
the books of the living lay open before him,
and his whole host in the heavens above and his council stood before him.[b]

4 The hearts of the holy ones were filled with joy,
for the full number of the just had drawn near,[c]
the prayer of the just had been answered,
and the blood of the just had been avenged before the Lord of Spirits.

Notes

- a (47:2) Compare Rev 6:9–11.
- b (47:3) Compare Dan 7:9–10; Rev 20:12.
- c (47:4) Had drawn near: or "had been reached" or "had been offered." Compare Rev 6:11.

Chapter 48

1 In that place I saw the spring of righteousness,
which never ran dry,
and around it were many springs of wisdom.
All the thirsty drank from them
and were filled with wisdom,
and their homes were with the righteous, the holy, and the chosen.
2 At that hour that Son of Man was given his name
before the Lord of Spirits,
his name spoken in the Head of Days' presence.
3 Even before the sun and the constellations were created,
before the stars of heaven were made,
his name was spoken before the Lord of Spirits.[a]
4 He will be a staff for the righteous,
to lean on so that they do not fall;
he will be the light of the nations
and the hope of those who grieve in their hearts.[b]
5 All who live on the dry ground will fall down and worship before him,
and will praise, bless, and sing to the Lord of Spirits.
6 For this reason he was chosen and hidden in his presence
before the world was created, and forever.
7 The wisdom of the Lord of Spirits has revealed him to the holy and the righteous,

for he guards the portion of the just,
since they loathed and spurned this world of wrongdoing
and detested all that is done in it and all its ways, in the Lord of Spirits' name.
By his name they find salvation,
and he is the one who will avenge their lives.[c]
8 In those days the kings of the earth will be downcast,
and the strong who hold the dry ground, because of the deeds of their hands;
for on the day of their anguish and distress they will not save themselves.
9 "I will hand them over to my chosen ones;
like straw in a fire they will burn before the holy,
like lead in water they will sink before the righteous,
and no trace of them will ever be found.
10 On the day of their distress there will be rest on the earth.
They will fall before him and not get up again,
and there will be no one to take them by the hand and lift them,
for they rejected the Lord of Spirits and his Anointed One."[d]
Blessed be the Lord of Spirits' name!

Notes

- a (48:3) Compare Ps 72:17, "May his name endure before the sun" (so the Greek and some Jewish interpretation).
- b (48:4) Compare Isa 42:6; 49:6; 61:1–2; Luke 2:32.
- c (48:7) He is the one who will avenge their lives: or "it is his will regarding their life."
- d (48:10) His Anointed One: Ge'ez *masiḥ*, "anointed," the word behind "Messiah" (Hebrew *mashiaḥ*) and "Christ" (Greek *christos*). Compare Ps 2:2. Here and at 52:4 the title is applied to the Son of Man.

Chapter 49

1 For wisdom is poured out like water,
and glory will never fail before him, forever and ever.
2 For he is mighty in all the secrets of righteousness,
and wrongdoing will pass away like a shadow
and will have no standing;

for the Chosen One has taken his stand before the Lord of Spirits,
and his glory is forever and ever,
and his power for all generations.
3 In him lives the spirit of wisdom,
the spirit that gives understanding,
the spirit of knowledge and power,
and the spirit of those who died in righteousness and sleep.[a]
4 He will judge hidden things,
and no one will be able to speak an empty word in his presence;
for he is the Chosen One before the Lord of Spirits, as he wills.

Notes

- a (49:3) Compare Isa 11:2.

Chapter 50

1 In those days a change will come for the holy and the chosen:
the light of days will rest on them,
and glory and honor will return to the holy ones
2 on the day of distress, when evil has been stored up against the sinners.
The righteous will triumph in the name of the Lord of Spirits,
and he will let the others see it,
so that they may repent
and abandon the works of their hands.
3 Before the Lord of Spirits they will receive no honor,
yet by his name they will find salvation,
and the Lord of Spirits will pity them,
for his mercy is great.[a]
4 He is righteous in his judgment,
and in the presence of his glory wrongdoing will not stand;
at his judgment whoever does not repent will perish before him.
5 "From then on I will show them no mercy," says the Lord of Spirits.

Notes

- a (50:3) Verses 2–3 envision a third group, "the others," who repent at the last moment and are saved without honor.

Chapter 51

1 In those days the earth will hand back what was entrusted to it,
Sheol will hand back what it has received,
and destruction will repay what it owes.[a]
2 He will pick out the righteous and holy from among them,
for the day of their salvation has come near.[b]
3 In those days the Chosen One will sit on my throne,[c]
and from his mouth will pour every secret of wisdom and counsel,
for the Lord of Spirits has granted them to him and glorified him.
4 In those days the mountains will bound like rams,
the hills will leap like lambs that have had their fill of milk,[d]
and the faces of all the angels in heaven will glow with joy.
5 For in those days the Chosen One will arise,
and the earth will rejoice;
the righteous will live on it,
and the chosen will go to and fro on it.

Notes

- a (51:1) Sheol: the Hebrew name for the realm of the dead. "Destruction" renders Ge'ez *haguel*, perhaps standing for Hebrew *Abaddon* (Job 26:6; Rev 9:11). The verse speaks of the resurrection of the dead; compare Dan 12:2; Rev 20:13.
- b (51:2) Verses 2 and 5a are given here in the manuscript order; Charles moves the line "For in those days the Chosen One will arise" to the start of verse 2.
- c (51:3) My throne: so most manuscripts; some read "his throne." God is the speaker.
- d (51:4) Compare Ps 114:4, 6.

Chapter 52

1 After those days, in the place where I had seen every vision of what is hidden—for a whirlwind had snatched me up and carried me westward—
2 my eyes saw there all the hidden things of heaven that are to come: a mountain of iron, a mountain of copper, a mountain of silver, a mountain of gold, a mountain of soft metal, and a mountain of lead.[a]
3 I asked the angel who went with me, "What are these hidden things I have seen?"
4 He told me, "Everything you have seen will serve the authority of his Anointed One, so that he may be strong and powerful on the earth."

5 That angel of peace replied, “Wait a little, and you will be shown
every hidden thing that surrounds the Lord of Spirits.
6 These mountains your eyes have seen—
of iron and of copper and of silver,
of gold, of soft metal, and of lead—
all of them will be before the Chosen One
like wax before fire,
like water pouring down from above onto those mountains;
they will grow weak under his feet.[b]
7 In those days no one will be saved
by gold or by silver,
and no one will be able to flee.
8 There will be no iron for battle,
no armor to put on;
bronze will be of no use,
tin will be worthless,
and lead will not be wanted.
9 All these will be wiped out from the face of the earth
when the Chosen One appears before the Lord of Spirits.”

Notes

- a (52:2) Soft metal: probably tin. The six mountains of metal may echo the metals of the statue in Dan 2:31–45, representing earthly empires and their wealth.
- b (52:6) Compare Mic 1:4; Ps 97:5.

Chapter 53

1 There my eyes saw a deep valley with gaping mouths. All who live
on the land, the sea, and the islands will bring it gifts, presents, and
tribute, but that deep valley will never be filled.
2 Their hands commit lawless acts;
whatever the righteous toil for, the sinners devour in their lawlessness.[a]
But the sinners will be destroyed before the Lord of Spirits,
banished from his earth,
and they will perish forever and ever.

3 For I saw all the angels of punishment staying there, getting ready
all the instruments of Satan.[b]
4 I asked the angel of peace who went with me, "For whom are they
getting these instruments ready?"
5 He told me, "They are preparing them for the kings and the powerful
of this earth, so that they may be destroyed by them.
6 After this the Righteous and Chosen One will make the house of his
congregation appear. From then on they will no longer be hindered,
in the name of the Lord of Spirits.
7 These mountains will not stand firm like the earth before his right-
eousness;[c]
the hills will become like a spring of water;
and the righteous will have rest from the harassment of sinners."

Notes

- a (53:2) Whatever the righteous toil for: so some manuscripts; others read "the sinners devour all whom they oppress."
- b (53:3) Satan: here a single chief adversary; compare the plural "satans" at 40:7.
- c (53:7) Will not stand firm like the earth: the sense is uncertain; perhaps "will be like level ground."

Chapter 54

1 I looked and turned toward another part of the earth, and there I
saw a deep valley burning with fire. 2 They were bringing the kings
and the powerful and throwing them into that deep valley. 3 There
my eyes watched them forging tools for it: chains of iron too heavy
to weigh. 4 I asked my companion, the angel of peace, "Who are these
chains being readied for?" 5 He told me, "They are being prepared for
the armies of Azazel,[a] so that they may seize them and hurl them into
the lowest part of the pit of damnation, and cover their jaws with
jagged stones, as the Lord of Spirits has ordered. 6 Michael, Gabriel,
Raphael, and Phanuel will grab hold of them on that great day and
throw them into the blazing furnace on that day, so that the Lord of
Spirits may punish them for their wickedness, because they became
servants of Satan and misled those who live on the dry ground."
7 In those days[b] punishment will go out from the Lord of Spirits. He
will open all the storerooms of the waters above the heavens and

the springs beneath the earth.[c] 8 All the waters will join together: the water above the heavens is the male, and the water beneath the earth is the female. 9 They will wipe out all who live on the dry ground and those who live under the ends of heaven. 10 Because of this they will come to recognize the wickedness they have done on the earth, and through these waters they will perish.

Notes

- a (54:5) *Azazel*: the Ethiopic form of the Aramaic *Asael*; see the note at 8:1. Compare Lev 16:8–10, 26.
- b (54:7) Verses 54:7–55:2 seem to belong to a separate "Book of Noah" tradition; compare 60:1–10, 24–25; 65–69:25; 106–107. They describe the first world judgment, the flood.
- c (54:7) Compare Gen 7:11.

Chapter 55

1 After that the Head of Days relented and said, "I have destroyed all who live on the dry ground for nothing." 2 He swore by his great name: "From now on I will not act this way toward all who live on the dry ground. I will put a sign in the sky, and it will be a pledge of good faith between me and them forever, as long as heaven stands above the earth.[a] This is in keeping with my command. 3 When I decide to seize them through the angels on the day of distress and pain, I will make my punishment and my anger rest on them," says God, the Lord of Spirits. 4 "You powerful kings who live on the dry ground, you will have to watch my Chosen One sit on the throne of glory and judge Azazel and all his companions and all his armies in the name of the Lord of Spirits."

Notes

- a (55:2) A sign in the sky: the rainbow (Gen 9:8–17). Compare Gen 8:21–22.

Chapter 56

1 There I saw troops of the angels of punishment marching, holding whips and chains of iron and bronze.

2 I asked my companion, the angel of peace, "Where are these whip-bearers headed?"

3 He told me, "Each to its own chosen and beloved ones,[a] so that they
may be flung into the chasm, the depths of the valley.
4 Then that valley will be filled with their chosen and beloved ones;
the days of their lives will be over,
and the days of their leading others astray will no longer be
counted.
5 In those days the angels will gather
and launch themselves eastward against the Parthians and Medes.[b]
They will stir up the kings, so that a spirit of turmoil comes over
them;
they will shake them from their thrones,
and they will burst out like lions from their dens
and like starving wolves among the flocks.
6 They will march up and trample the land of his chosen ones,
and the land of his chosen ones will be before them like a threshing
floor and a beaten path.
7 But the city of my righteous ones will be an obstacle to their horses.[c]
They will start fighting each other;
their own right hands will be strong against them;
a man will not acknowledge his brother,
nor a son his father or his mother,
until the corpses from their slaughter are past counting,
and their punishment will not be in vain.
8 In those days Sheol will open its jaws,
and they will sink into it;
their destruction will be complete.
Sheol will swallow the sinners in the presence of the chosen."

Notes

- a (56:3) Its own chosen and beloved ones: that is, the favorites of the fallen angels, the giants (compare 10:12; 14:6).
- b (56:5) The Parthians and Medes: the Parthian empire, east of the Euphrates, which invaded Syria and Judea in 40 BC. Many date the Parables partly by this allusion. *Medes*: the ancient people of Media, in northwest Iran.
- c (56:7) The city of my righteous ones: Jerusalem. Compare Ezek 38–39; Zech 14:2–3, 13.

Chapter 57

1 After this I saw another army, of wagons with men riding on them,
coming on the winds from the east and from the west toward the
south.[a] 2 The rumble of their wagons was heard, and when that uproar
happened, the holy ones in heaven took notice, and the pillars of the
earth were shaken from their places. The noise of it was heard from
one end of heaven to the other for one day. 3 Every one of them will
bow low in worship before the Lord of Spirits. This is the end of the
second discourse.

Notes

- a (57:1) This verse is often read as the return of the scattered Jews of the diaspora to Jerusalem; compare Isa 43:5–6; 49:22; 66:20.

Chapter 58

1 I began to speak the third discourse, about the righteous and the
chosen.

2 How happy you will be, righteous and chosen ones,
for your lot will be glorious!

3 The righteous will live in the sunlight,
and the chosen in the light of everlasting life.
There will be no end to the days of their life,
and no counting the days of the holy ones.

4 They will seek the light and find righteousness with the Lord of
Spirits.
Peace will belong to the righteous in the name of the Lord of the
ages.

5 After this the holy ones in heaven will be told
to search out the secrets of righteousness, the inheritance of faith;
for it has risen like the sun on the dry ground,
and darkness has gone by.

6 There will be unending light,
and they will never come to an end of days,
for the darkness will first have been destroyed,
and the light of uprightness will stand firm forever before the Lord
of Spirits.

Chapter 59

1 In those days my eyes saw the secrets of the lightning and the lights
and the judgments they carry out. They flash for blessing or for curse,
as the Lord of Spirits wills. 2 There I saw the secrets of the thunder:
how, when it crashes in the heights of heaven, its sound is heard. He
let me see the judgments carried out on the earth, whether for well-
being and blessing or for curse, according to the word of the Lord of
Spirits. 3 After that all the secrets of the lights and of the lightning
were shown to me: they flash for blessing and for plenty.

Chapter 60

1 In Enoch's life, year five hundred, month seven, day fourteen.[a] In
that discourse I saw how a violent shaking shook the heaven of
heavens, and the host of the Most High, the angels, thousands upon
thousands and myriads upon myriads, were greatly disturbed.
2 The Head of Days was sitting on the throne of his glory, with the
angels and the righteous standing around him.
3 Great trembling seized me,
terror took hold of me;
my waist gave way,
my insides dissolved,
and I fell on my face.
4 Michael sent another angel, one of the holy ones, and he lifted me
up. When he had lifted me up, my spirit came back to me, for I had not
been able to bear the sight of that host, the uproar, and the shaking
of heaven.
5 Michael said to me, "Why does a sight like this disturb you? Until
today the day of his mercy has lasted; he has been merciful and slow
to anger toward those who live on the dry ground.
6 But when the day comes, with the power, the punishment, and the
judgment that the Lord of Spirits has made ready for those who do
not bow to the just law, for those who deny the just judgment, and
for those who take his name in vain—that day has been made ready:
for the chosen a covenant, but for sinners an investigation."

7 On that day two monsters will be separated from each other: a female monster named Leviathan,[b] to live in the depths of the sea above
the springs of the waters, 8 and the male named Behemoth, who fills
with his chest a trackless wilderness named Dendayin,[c] east of the
garden where the chosen and righteous live, where my grandfather
was received up,[d] he who was seventh from Adam, the first human
being whom the Lord of Spirits created. 9 I asked the other angel to
show me the strength of those monsters, how they were separated
on one day and thrown, one into the depths of the sea and the other
onto the dry ground of the wilderness. 10 He said to me, "You, son of
man,[e] are seeking to know what is hidden."
11 The other angel, who went with me and showed me hidden things,
told me what is first and last in heaven, in the height, and beneath
the dry ground, in the depth, and at the ends of heaven and at the
foundations of heaven, 12 and about the storerooms of the winds: how
the winds are divided up, how they are weighed, and how the gates of
the winds are counted, each by the strength of its wind; the strength
of the moon's light, and how its strength is suited; the divisions of
the stars by their names, and how every division is marked off; 13 the
thunderclaps, by the places where they fall; all the divisions made
among the lightning flashes so that they may flash; and their host,
so that they obey at once. 14 The thunder has resting places, assigned
to it while it waits for its crash. Thunder and lightning cannot be
parted; though they are not one and the same, they travel together
through the wind and do not separate. 15 For when the lightning
flashes, the thunder sounds its voice, and the wind gives it rest at the
right moment, dividing evenly between them. The storehouse of their
crashes is like sand; each of them, as it crashes, is held back with a
bridle, turned back by the power of the wind, and driven on to the
many regions of the earth. 16 The wind of the sea is male and strong.
By the might of its strength it reins the sea back, and in the same
way it drives it forward and scatters it among all the mountains of
the earth. 17 The wind of the frost is its own angel, and the wind of the
hail is a good angel. 18 The wind of the snow has left its storerooms
because of its strength. There is a special wind in it, and what rises

from it is like smoke; its name is hoarfrost. 19 The wind of the mist does not share their storerooms; it has a storeroom of its own, for its course is glorious in light and in darkness, in winter and in summer, and an angel is in its storeroom. 20 The wind of the dew lives at the ends of heaven and is joined to the storerooms of the rain. Its course is in winter and in summer, and its clouds and the clouds of the mist are joined; one gives to the other. 21 When the wind of the rain goes out of its storeroom, the angels come, open the storeroom, and lead it out. When it spreads over the whole dry ground, it unites with the water on the earth; and whenever it unites with the water on the earth . . .[f] 22 For the waters are for those who live on the dry ground; they are nourishment for the earth from the Most High in heaven. So there is a fixed measure for the rain, and the angels are in charge of it. 23 All this I saw near the Garden of the Righteous. 24 The angel of peace who was with me said to me, "These two monsters, prepared in keeping with the greatness of the Lord, will feed . . .[g] 25 so that the punishment of the Lord of Spirits may not come upon them for nothing. Children will be killed with their mothers, and children with their fathers. When the punishment of the Lord of Spirits rests on them, it will stay on them, so that the punishment of the Lord of Spirits may not be in vain. After that the judgment will take place in keeping with his mercy and his patience."[h]

Notes

- a (60:1) In the life of Enoch: the date originally belonged to Noah (compare Gen 7:6, 11, where Noah is 600 at the flood); the editor who placed this Noah fragment here changed the name, but verse 8 still has Noah speaking of "my grandfather." *The seventh month*: in the Jewish calendar Tishri, roughly September–October, the month of the Day of Atonement and Tabernacles; on the 364-day calendar of 1 Enoch and Jubilees, see the notes at chapter 72.
- b (60:7) *Leviathan*: Hebrew *liwyatan*, perhaps "coiled one," the sea monster of Job 41; Ps 74:14; 104:26; Isa 27:1. *Behemoth*: Hebrew plural of *behemah*, "beast," meaning "the great beast" (Job 40:15–24).
- c (60:8) *Dendayin*: the manuscripts vary (*Dendāin*, *Dâidâin*, *Dûidâin*). Perhaps a form of the desert "Dudael" (10:4), or of Nod "east of Eden" (Gen 4:16).
- d (60:8) My grandfather: Enoch, grandfather of Noah's father Lamech; so the speaker here is Noah (see the note at verse 1). Enoch was "the seventh from Adam" (Gen 5:3–24; Jude 14).

- e (60:10) Son of man: here simply "human being, mortal," as in Ezekiel (Ezek 2:1).
- f (60:21) The text is broken off here in all manuscripts.
- g (60:24) Will feed: the text is broken. Later Jewish tradition held that Leviathan and Behemoth would be food for the righteous at the end (4 Ezra 6:49–52; 2 Bar 29:4).
- h (60:25) The order and wording of verses 24–25 are confused in the manuscripts; this rendering follows the reconstruction generally adopted.

Chapter 61

1 In those days I saw long cords handed to those angels. They took wings for themselves and flew off northward.

2 I asked the angel, "Why have they taken those cords and gone?" He answered, "They have gone off to measure."

3 The angel who went with me said,

"These will bring the measurements of the righteous
and the measuring lines of the righteous to the righteous,
so that they may lean on the Lord of Spirits' name forever and ever.[a]

4 The chosen will begin to live with the chosen;
these are the measurements that will be given to faith
and will make righteousness firm.

5 These measurements will bring to light every secret of the depths of the earth,
those swallowed up by the desert,
those eaten by wild animals,
and those eaten by the fish of the sea,
so that they may come back and find support
on the day of the Chosen One;
for no one will be lost before the Lord of Spirits,
and no one can be lost."

6 All who are in the heights of heaven received a command, a power, one voice, and one light like fire.

7 With their first words they blessed that one,
and they praised and exalted him with wisdom,
showing wisdom in speech and in the spirit of life.

[8] The Lord of Spirits placed the Chosen One on the throne of glory,[b]
and he will judge all the works of the holy ones in heaven above,
and weigh their deeds in the scales.
[9] When he raises his face
to judge their hidden ways by the word of the Lord of Spirits' name,
and their paths by the way of the just judgment of the Lord of Spirits,
then with one voice they will all speak and bless,
glorify, exalt, and hallow the Lord of Spirits' name.
[10] He will call the whole host of heaven, all the holy ones above, the host of the Lord—the cherubim, the seraphim, and the ophanim,[c] all the angels of power and all the angels of dominion—and the Chosen One, and the other powers that are on the dry ground and over the water.
[11] On that day they will lift a single voice. They will bless, glorify, and exalt in a spirit of faith, of wisdom, of patience, of mercy, of justice and peace, and of goodness, and all will say together, "Blessed is he, and blessed be the Lord of Spirits' name forever and ever!"
[12] All in heaven above who never sleep will bless him;
every holy one in heaven will bless him,
and all the chosen who live in the garden of life,
and every spirit of light that can bless, glorify, exalt, and hallow your blessed name;
and all flesh will glorify and bless your name beyond all measure, forever and ever.
[13] For the Lord of Spirits abounds in mercy and is patient;
all his works and all that he has made
he has revealed to the righteous and the chosen
in the Lord of Spirits' name.

Notes

- a (61:3) Measurements… measuring lines: images of resurrection and restoration; compare Zech 2:1–5; Ezek 40:3; Rev 11:1.
- b (61:8) Placed… on the throne: so some manuscripts; others read "The Lord of Spirits sat on the throne of his glory."
- c (61:10) Cherubim, seraphim, ophanim: classes of heavenly beings. *Cherubim* (Hebrew *keruvim*, meaning uncertain) guard Eden and the ark (Gen 3:24; Exod

25:18–22); *seraphim*, “burning ones” (Isa 6:2); *ophanim*, “wheels” (Ezek 1:15–21; 10:9–13). Compare 71:7.

Chapter 62

1 This is what the Lord commanded the kings, the powerful, the exalted, and those who inhabit the dry ground: “Open your eyes and raise your horns,[a] if you can recognize the Chosen One.”

2 The Lord of Spirits seated him[b] on his glorious throne,
and the spirit of righteousness was poured out on him.
The word of his mouth kills every sinner,
and all the lawless are wiped out before him.[c]

3 On that day all the kings and the powerful,
the exalted and those who hold the dry ground,
will rise up and see and know
that he sits on his glorious throne;
righteousness is judged in his presence,
and no false word is spoken before him.

4 Then pain will come over them
like that of a woman in labor
who struggles to give birth
when her child comes to the mouth of the womb.

5 One group of them will look at the other;
they will be terrified,
their faces will fall,
and pain will grip them
when they see that Son of a Woman[d]
seated on his glorious throne.

6 The kings, the powerful, and all who possess the dry ground will bless, glorify, and exalt the one who rules over everything, who had been hidden.

7 For from the start the Son of Man was hidden;
the Most High kept him in the presence of his power
and revealed him to the chosen.

8 The community of the chosen and holy will be sown,[e]
and all the chosen will stand before him on that day.

9 All the kings, the powerful, the exalted, and those who rule the dry ground
will fall face down before him,
worship him, set their hope on that Son of Man,
and beg him and plead for mercy from him.
10 But the Lord of Spirits will press them so hard
that they will rush from his presence;
their faces will be full of shame,
and darkness will pile up on their faces.
11 He will hand them over to the angels of punishment
to take vengeance on them,
because they oppressed his children and his chosen ones.
12 They will be a spectacle for the righteous and for his chosen ones.
They will rejoice over them,
because the anger of the Lord of Spirits rests on them
and his sword is drunk with their blood.[f]
13 The righteous and chosen will be saved on that day,
and from then on they will never again see the faces of the sinners and the lawless.
14 The Lord of Spirits will live over them;
with that Son of Man they will eat,
lie down, and rise, forever and ever.
15 The righteous and chosen will have risen from the earth
and will no longer go about with downcast faces.
16 They will be dressed in garments of glory,
garments of life from the Lord of Spirits.
Your garments will not wear out,
and your glory will not fade before the Lord of Spirits.[g]

Notes

- a (62:1) Raise your horns: an idiom for showing strength or pride (Ps 75:4–5).
- b (62:2) Seated him: so with a slight change; the manuscripts read "sat on."
- c (62:2) Compare Isa 11:2, 4; Ps Sol 17:24; Rev 19:15.
- d (62:5) Son of a Woman: Ge'ez *walda be'si*, "son of a man" in most manuscripts; some read *walda ʿeguāla ʿemma-ḥeyāw*, "son of the offspring of the mother of the living," that is, of Eve. See the note at 46:2.
- e (62:8) Will be sown: that is, will be planted and grow; compare 10:16; 93:2, 5, 10.

- f (62:12) Compare Isa 34:5–6; Deut 32:42.
- g (62:16) Compare 2 Cor 5:2–4; Rev 3:4–5; 6:11.

Chapter 63

1 In those days the powerful and the kings who possess the dry ground
will beg his angels of punishment, to whom they have been handed
over, to give them a short break, so that they may bow in worship to
the Lord of Spirits and acknowledge their sins to him.
2 They will bless and glorify the Lord of Spirits, saying:
"Blessed is the Lord of Spirits, the Lord of kings,
Lord of the powerful and Lord of the rich,
Lord of glory and Lord of wisdom.
3 Every hidden thing shines with your power from generation to
generation,
and your glory endures forever and ever.
Your secrets are deep and past counting,
and your righteousness is beyond reckoning.
4 Now we have learned that we ought to glorify
and bless the Lord of kings, the one who is King over all kings."
5 They will say, "If only we had a pause to glorify, give thanks,
and confess our faith before his glory!
6 Now we long for a little rest but do not find it;
we chase it but cannot catch it.
Light has gone from before us,
and darkness is our home forever and ever.
7 For we did not believe in him
or glorify the Lord of Spirits' name;
our hope was in the scepter of our kingdom
and in our own splendor.
8 On the day of our suffering and distress he does not save us,
and we find no break in which to confess
that our Lord is faithful in all his deeds, his judgments, and his
justice,
and that his judgments show no partiality.

9 We vanish from his presence because of our deeds,
and every one of our sins has been counted out exactly."
10 Then they will say to themselves, "Our souls are stuffed with ill-gotten wealth, but it does not stop us from going down out of it into the flames of the torment of Sheol."[a]
11 After that their faces will be filled with darkness
and shame before that Son of Man;
they will be driven from his presence,
and the sword will stay before him among them.
12 So says the Lord of Spirits: "This is the decree and the judgment against the powerful, the kings, the exalted, and those who possess the dry ground, in the presence of the Lord of Spirits."

Notes

- a (63:10) The flames of the torment of Sheol: so some manuscripts; others read "the weight" or "the burden of Sheol." Compare Luke 16:23–24.

Chapter 64

1 I saw other figures hidden in that place. 2 I heard the angel's voice say, "These are the angels who came down to the earth, disclosed hidden things to humankind, and led human beings into sin."

Chapter 65

1 In those days Noah[a] saw that the earth had tilted and that its ruin was near.
2 He got up from there and went to the ends of the earth and cried out to his great-grandfather Enoch.[b] In an anguished voice Noah said three times, "Hear me, hear me, hear me!"
3 I said to him, "Tell me what is happening on the earth, that the earth is so battered and shaken, or I may perish with it."
4 Just then there was a great upheaval on the earth; a voice sounded from heaven, and I dropped face down.
5 My great-grandfather Enoch came and stood beside me and said, "Why have you cried out to me so bitterly and with tears?
6 A command has gone out from the Lord against those who live on the dry ground, that their end is to be carried out, because they have

learned all the secrets of the angels, all the violence of the satans and all their most secret powers, all the power of those who practice sorcery and spells, and the power of those who cast idols for the whole earth;

7 how silver comes from the dust of the earth, and how soft metal comes into being on the earth.

8 For lead and tin are not produced from the earth as the first is; there is a spring that produces them, and an angel stands in it, and that angel is prominent."

9 After that my great-grandfather Enoch took me by the hand, raised me up, and said to me, "Go, for I have asked the Lord of Spirits about this upheaval on the earth.

10 He told me, 'Because of their lawlessness their judgment has been decided, and I will not hold it back any longer. Because of the sorceries they have searched out and learned, the earth and its inhabitants will be destroyed.'

11 For these there will never be a place of repentance, because they have revealed what was hidden, and they are condemned. But as for you, my son, the Lord of Spirits knows that you are pure and innocent of this blame concerning the secrets.

12 He has set your name among the holy ones
and will keep you safe among those who live on the dry ground;
he has destined your righteous offspring for kingship and great honor,
and from your offspring will come a spring of the righteous and holy, past counting, forever."

Notes

- a (65:1) *Noah*: Hebrew *Noaḥ*, connected in Gen 5:29 with *naḥam*, "to comfort," and with *nuaḥ*, "to rest." Chapters 65–69:25 are another piece of the Noah tradition (see the note at 54:7); Noah speaks in the first person.
- b (65:2) Great-grandfather: so the sense; the text has "grandfather" (Ge'ez uses the word loosely). By Gen 5:21–29 Enoch is Noah's great-grandfather: Enoch, Methuselah, Lamech, Noah.

Chapter 66

1 After that he showed me the angels of punishment who are ready
to come and unleash all the forces of the water that lies under the
earth, to bring judgment and destruction on all who live on the dry
ground. 2 The Lord of Spirits ordered the angels who were going out
not to raise the waters but to hold them back, for those angels were
in charge of the forces of the waters. 3 Then I left Enoch's presence.

Chapter 67

1 In those days the word of God came to me, and he said to me, "Noah,
your lot has come up before me, a lot free of blame, a lot of love and
uprightness. 2 Now the angels are building a wooden structure,[a] and
when they have finished the task I will lay my hand on it and keep it
safe. From it will come the seed of life, and a change will take place,
so that the earth will not be left empty. 3 I will establish your offspring
before me forever and ever, and I will scatter abroad those who live
with you. It will not be barren on the face of the dry ground, but it
will be blessed and will multiply on the earth in the name of the Lord."
4 He will lock up those angels who displayed lawlessness in that
burning valley that my great-grandfather Enoch had shown me
earlier in the west, near the mountains of gold, silver, iron, soft metal,
and tin.[b] 5 I saw that valley, in which there was a great churning and
a heaving of the waters. 6 When all this happened, from that fiery
molten metal and from the churning in that place, a smell of sulfur
arose and mixed with those waters. That valley of the angels who had
led people astray burned beneath that ground. 7 Through its valleys
flow rivers of fire, where those angels are punished who led astray the
inhabitants of the dry ground. 8 But in those days those waters will
serve the kings, the powerful, the exalted, and those who live on the
dry ground for the healing of body and soul,[c] and for the punishment
of the spirit. Their spirits are full of lust, so that they will be punished
in their bodies, for they have denied the Lord of Spirits. They see their
punishment every day, yet they do not believe in his name. 9 As the
burning of their bodies grows fierce, a matching change will come
over their spirits forever and ever, for no one will speak an idle word

before the Lord of Spirits. [10] For judgment will come on them, because they trust in the lust of their bodies and deny the Spirit of the Lord. [11] Those same waters will change in those days. When those angels are punished in these waters, the springs will change their heat; and when the angels come up, the spring water will change and turn cold. [12] I heard Michael respond, "This judgment by which the angels are judged is a witness against the kings and the powerful who possess the dry ground. [13] For these waters of judgment serve the healing of the kings' bodies and the lust of their bodies; so they will not see or believe that those waters will change and become a fire that burns forever."

Notes

- a (67:2) A wooden structure: the ark (Gen 6:14–16). Here angels build it.
- b (67:4) Compare 52:2 and 53:1; 54:1.
- c (67:8) Healing of body and soul: so the manuscripts; Charles emends to "for the healing of the body, but for the punishment of the spirit." The hot springs may allude to those used by Herod the Great at Callirrhoe by the Dead Sea, about 4 BC (Josephus, *Antiquities* 17.171–173).

Chapter 68

[1] After that my great-grandfather Enoch instructed me in every secret contained in the book of the discourses that had been given to him, and he gathered them for me into the words of the book of the discourses. [2] On that day Michael spoke up and said to Raphael, "The force of the spirit carries me away and makes me tremble at the severity of the judgment of the secrets, the judgment of the angels. Who can bear the harsh judgment that has been carried out, before which they melt?" [3] Again Michael spoke up and said to Raphael, "Who would not be softened in heart about it, and whose insides would not be troubled by this word of judgment passed against them, against those whom they have led out like this?" [4] When he stood before the Lord of Spirits, Michael said to Raphael, "I will not take their side under the eye of the Lord, for the Lord of Spirits is angry with them because they behave as if they were the Lord. [5] That is why everything hidden will come upon them forever and ever. Neither

angel nor human will have a share in it; they alone have received their judgment forever and ever."

Chapter 69

1 After this judgment they will terrify them and make them tremble, because they revealed this to those who live on the dry ground. 2 Here are the names of those angels.[a] The first of them is Semyaza; the second Artaqifa; the third Armen; the fourth Kokabel; the fifth Turael; the sixth Rumyal; the seventh Danyal; the eighth Neqael; the ninth Baraqel; the tenth Azazel; the eleventh Armaros; the twelfth Batryal; the thirteenth Basasael; the fourteenth Ananel; the fifteenth Turel; the sixteenth Simapesiel; the seventeenth Yetrel; the eighteenth Tumael; the nineteenth Turel; the twentieth Rumael; the twenty-first Azazel. 3 These are the leaders of their angels and their names, their chiefs over hundreds, over fifties, and over tens.

4 The name of the first is Yeqon.[b] He is the one who led all the children of God astray, brought them down to the earth, and misled them through the daughters of humankind.

5 The second is named Asbeel. He gave evil counsel to the holy children of God and misled them into defiling their bodies with human women.

6 The third is named Gadreel. He is the one who showed human beings every deadly blow. He led Eve astray,[c] and showed human beings the weapons of death: shield, breastplate, and sword for battle, and every weapon of death.

7 From his hand they have gone out against those who live on the dry ground from that day and forever.

8 The fourth is named Penemue. He taught human beings bitter and sweet, and taught them all the secrets of their wisdom.

9 He showed people how to write with ink and paper,[d] and through this many have sinned from age to age until this day.

10 Human beings were not created for this, to confirm their good faith with pen and ink.

11 For humans were created no differently from the angels, to stay righteous and pure, and death, which ruins everything, would not

have touched them. But through this knowledge of theirs they are perishing, and through this power it is devouring me.[e]

12 The fifth is named Kasdeya. He showed human beings all the evil blows of spirits and demons: the blows that strike the embryo in the womb so that it miscarries, the bites of the snake, and the blows that come in the midday heat, the snake's offspring, whose name is Tabaet.[f]

13 This is Kasbeel's task: he is chief of the oath, which he disclosed to the holy ones while he dwelt in the glory on high; its name is Biqa.

14 This one asked Michael to show him the hidden name, so that he might pronounce it in the oath, so that those who revealed every secret thing to humankind would tremble before that name and oath.

15 Such is the force of this oath, mighty and strong. He put this oath, Akae, in Michael's hand.

16 These are the secrets of this oath,
and they are made firm by his oath:
heaven was hung up before the world was created,
and forever.

17 By it the earth was founded on the water,
and from the hidden places of the mountains come lovely waters,
from the creation of the world and forever.

18 By that oath the sea was created,
and for its foundation he set the sand against the time of its fury,
and it dares not go beyond it, from the creation of the world and forever.[g]

19 By that oath the depths are made fast;
they stay and do not move from their place, from age to age.

20 By that oath the sun and moon complete their courses
and do not swerve from their decree, from age to age.

21 By that oath the stars complete their courses;
he summons each by name,
and they reply to him, from age to age.[h]

22 So too the spirits of the water and of the winds, of all the breezes, and their paths from every quarter of the winds.

23 There the voices of the thunder and the light of the lightning are kept, and there the storerooms of the hail and of the frost are kept, the storerooms of the mist and of the rain and dew.
24 All of them believe and offer thanks to the Lord of Spirits and give him glory with all their might; their food is all thanksgiving. They thank, glorify, and exalt the Lord of Spirits' name forever and ever.
25 This oath is strong over them;
by it they are kept, their paths are kept,
and their course is not destroyed.
26 There was great joy among them;
they blessed, glorified, and exalted,
because the name of that Son of Man had been revealed to them.
27 He sat on his glorious throne,
and the whole of judgment was handed over to the Son of Man.[i]
He makes the sinners vanish and be destroyed from the face of the earth,
together with those who led the world astray.
28 They will be bound with chains
and locked up in the gathering place of their destruction,
and all their works will vanish from the face of the earth.
29 From then on nothing will be corruptible,
for that Son of Man has come into view
and is seated on his glorious throne.
All evil will pass away before him,
and the word of that Son of Man will go out
and prevail before the Lord of Spirits.
Here ends Enoch's third discourse.

Notes

- a (69:2) This list largely repeats 6:7, in corrupted Ethiopic forms; compare the notes there. *Shemihazah* appears as *Semyaza*; *Asael* appears twice (as *Azazel*).
- b (69:4) *Yeqon*: perhaps "he will incite" (Hebrew *yaqum*, "he rises"). *Asbeel*: perhaps "deserter from God." *Gadreel*: "God is my helper" or "wall of God." *Penemue*: perhaps "inside" or "face." *Kasdeya*: "Chaldean," recalling the Chaldeans as experts in magic and astrology. *Kasbeel*: perhaps "deceiver of God." *Biqa*: perhaps "request" or "the one who asks." *Akae*: meaning unknown; some connect it with *ʾ-k-y*, "to name."

- c (69:6) He led Eve astray: here the serpent of Gen 3 is identified with a fallen angel; compare Wis 2:24; Rev 12:9.
- d (69:9) Paper: papyrus. Writing itself is here counted among the forbidden arts, in contrast to Enoch the scribe (12:4) and to Jubilees 4:17, where Enoch is the first to learn writing.
- e (69:11) It is devouring me: perhaps "death is devouring us"; the text is uncertain.
- f (69:12) Midday heat: compare Ps 91:6. *Tabaet*: perhaps "male" or "strong"; the meaning is uncertain.
- g (69:18) Compare Job 38:8–11; Jer 5:22.
- h (69:21) Compare Isa 40:26; Bar 3:34–35.
- i (69:27) Compare John 5:22, 27.

Chapter 70

1 After this, while he was still alive, his name was lifted up into the
presence of that Son of Man and into the presence of the Lord of
Spirits, away from those who live on the dry ground.[a] 2 He was raised
on the chariots of the wind,[b] and his name departed from among
them. 3 From that day I was no longer counted among them. He set
me between two winds, between north and west, where the angels
had taken the cords to mark out for me a place for the chosen and
the righteous. 4 There I saw the first ancestors and the righteous who
from the beginning have lived in that place.

Notes

- a (70:1) Chapters 70–71 describe Enoch's final removal from earth; compare Gen 5:24, "Enoch walked with God, and he was no more, for God took him." The narrative shifts from third person (70:1–2) to first person (70:3).
- b (70:2) The chariots of the wind: or "of the spirit"; compare Elijah in 2 Kgs 2:11.

Chapter 71

1 After this my spirit was taken away
and went up into the heavens.
I saw the children of God[a]
stepping on flames of fire;
their garments were white,
and their faces shone like snow.
2 I saw two rivers of fire,
whose fire gleamed like hyacinth,[b]
and I threw myself face down before the Lord of Spirits.

3 The angel Michael, one of the archangels, took me by my right hand,
lifted me up, and led me out into all the secrets;
he showed me all the secrets of mercy and of righteousness.
4 He showed me all the secrets of the ends of heaven,
all the storerooms of all the stars and all the lights,
from where they come out before the holy ones.
5 He carried my spirit off into the heaven of heavens,
and there I saw something like a structure built of crystals,[c]
and between the crystals tongues of living fire.
6 My spirit saw a ring of fire encircling that house;
on its four sides were rivers full of living fire,
and they encircled that house.
7 Around it were seraphim, cherubim, and ophanim;
these are the ones who never sleep
and who guard the throne of his glory.
8 I saw angels past counting,
thousands upon thousands and myriads upon myriads,
surrounding that house.
Michael, Raphael, Gabriel, and Phanuel,
and the holy angels in heaven above,
go in and out of that house.
9 Out of that house came Michael and Gabriel, Raphael and Phanuel,
and many holy angels beyond number,
10 and the Head of Days came with them,
his head pure and white like wool,
his robes past describing.
11 I fell on my face;
my whole body went limp,
and my spirit was transformed.
I cried out in a loud voice,
with a spirit of power,
and I blessed, glorified, and exalted.
12 These blessings that came from my mouth pleased that Head of Days.

13 That Head of Days came, accompanied by Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Phanuel,
and thousands and myriads of angels past counting.
14 He[d] came to me, greeted me with his voice, and said to me,
"You are that son of man[e] who was born for righteousness;
righteousness rests on you,
and the righteousness of the Head of Days will not abandon you."
15 He said to me,
"He proclaims peace to you in the name of the age to come,
for from there peace has gone out since the creation of the world,
and so you will have it forever and ever and ever.
16 Everyone will walk in your ways,
since righteousness will never abandon you;
with you will be their homes, and with you their inheritance,
and they will not be parted from you forever and ever and ever.
17 So with that son of man there will be long life,
and the righteous will have peace and an upright way
in the Lord of Spirits' name forever and ever."

Notes

- a (71:1) The children of God: angels; compare 6:2; Job 1:6.
- b (71:2) Hyacinth: a precious stone, probably blue (sapphire or jacinth).
- c (71:5) Crystals: or "hailstones"; compare 14:9–10.
- d (71:14) He: the angel, or perhaps the Head of Days himself. Charles assumes a passage has been lost before this verse and changes "you" to "this."
- e (71:14) You are that son of man: so all the Ethiopic manuscripts. Here Enoch himself is identified with the heavenly figure of the Parables, or, as many read it, is simply called "a human being born for righteousness" (compare 60:10). Charles and some translators emend to "This is the Son of Man." This translation follows the manuscripts.

Chapter 72

The Astronomical Book (chapters 72–82)

1 The book of the movements of the lights of heaven, each as it is, by their kinds, their authority, and their seasons, by their names and their places of rising, and by their months, which Uriel, the holy angel who was with me and who is their guide, showed me. He showed me

their whole design exactly as it is, for every year of the world and forever, until the new creation is made that lasts forever.[a] 2 This is the first law of the lights. The light called the sun rises in the eastern gates of heaven and sets in the western gates of heaven. 3 I saw six gates where the sun rises and six gates where the sun sets. The moon also rises and sets in these gates, as do the leaders of the stars with those they lead: six in the east and six in the west, all lined up exactly, one after another. There are also many windows to the right and left of these gates.[b] 4 First the great light named the sun comes out. Its circle is like the circle of heaven, and it is entirely full of fire that gives light and heat. 5 The wind drives the chariot on which it rides up. The sun goes down out of the sky and turns back by way of the north to reach the east, and it is guided so that it arrives at the proper gate and shines in the face of the sky. 6 In this way it rises in the first month[c] in the great gate, which is the fourth of those six gates in the east. 7 In that fourth gate, from which the sun rises in the first month, there are twelve window openings, from which flame comes out when they are opened at their time. 8 When the sun rises in the sky, it comes out through that fourth gate for thirty mornings in a row and sets exactly in the fourth gate in the west of the sky. 9 Through this period each day grows longer and each night shorter, until the thirtieth morning. 10 By then daylight exceeds darkness by one ninth: the day comes to exactly ten parts and the night to eight.[d] 11 The sun rises from that fourth gate and sets in the fourth, then moves to the fifth gate of the east for thirty mornings, rising from it and setting in the fifth gate. 12 Then the day grows longer by two parts and comes to eleven parts, and the night grows shorter and comes to seven parts.[e] 13 It returns to the east and enters the sixth gate, and rises and sets in the sixth gate for thirty-one mornings, because of its sign.[f] 14 On that day the day is longer than the night, so that the day is twice the night: the day becomes twelve parts, and the night is cut back to six parts. 15 Then the sun rises so as to make the day shorter and the night longer. The sun goes back to the east and enters the sixth gate, and rises and sets from it for thirty mornings. 16 When the thirty mornings are over, the day has lost exactly one part and is eleven parts, and the night seven.

17 The sun leaves that sixth gate in the west, goes to the east, and rises
in the fifth gate for thirty mornings, and sets again in the west in the
fifth western gate. 18 On that day the day has lost two parts; the day
comes to ten parts and the night to eight. 19 The sun leaves that fifth
gate and sets in the fifth gate of the west, and rises in the fourth gate
for thirty-one mornings because of its sign, and sets in the west. 20 On
that day the day equals the night; they are of equal length, the night
nine parts and the day nine.[g] 21 The sun rises from that gate and sets in
the west, then returns to the east and rises in the third gate for thirty
mornings and sets in the west in the third gate. 22 On that day the
night grows longer than the day, each night longer than the last and
each day shorter than the last until the thirtieth morning; the night
comes to exactly ten parts and the day to eight. 23 Leaving the third
gate, where it rose and set in the west, the sun goes back east and
rises out of the second eastern gate for thirty mornings, and likewise
sets in the second gate in the west of the sky. 24 On that day the night
comes to eleven parts and the day to seven. 25 On that day the sun rises
from that second gate and sets in the west in the second gate, and
returns to the east into the first gate for thirty-one mornings, and sets
in the first gate in the west of the sky. 26 On that day the night grows
long and becomes double the day: the night is exactly twelve parts
and the day six.[h] 27 With that the sun has gone through the stages of
its circuit, and it turns back over those same stages: it enters that gate
for thirty mornings and sets also in the west opposite it. 28 That night
the night has shortened by a ninth, to eleven parts, and the day is
seven parts. 29 The sun comes back and enters the second gate in the
east and returns over those stages of its circuit for thirty mornings,
rising and setting. 30 On that day the night shortens: the night comes
to ten parts and the day to eight. 31 On that day the sun rises from that
gate and sets in the west, returns to the east, and rises in the third
gate for thirty-one mornings, and sets in the west of the sky. 32 On that
day the night has shortened to nine parts and the day is nine parts;
night equals day, and the year comes to exactly three hundred and
sixty-four days.[i] 33 The lengthening of the day and the night, and the
shortening of the day and the night, all come about through the sun's

course; by it they are made different. [34] So its course grows longer by day and shorter by night.[j] [35] This is the law and course of the sun and its return, as often as it returns: sixty times it rises and goes back.[k] That is, the great light called the sun, forever and ever. [36] What rises in this way is the great light, and it is named by its appearance, as the Lord commanded. [37] As it rises, so it sets; it does not grow less and does not rest, but runs day and night. Its light is seven times brighter than the moon's, but in size the two are equal.

Notes

- a (72:1) This section, often called the Astronomical Book or the Book of the Luminaries, is the oldest part of 1 Enoch; Aramaic fragments of a longer form (4QEnastr a–d) are reported to date from about 200 BC or earlier. It sets out a schematic solar year of 364 days: exactly 52 weeks, divided into four quarters of 91 days, each made of two 30-day months and one 31-day month. Because 364 is divisible by 7, every date falls on the same day of the week every year, and festivals never fall on a sabbath. The same calendar is defended in Jubilees and was used by the Qumran community. It runs about 1¼ days short of the true solar year (about 365.24 days); the text never addresses the gap.
- b (72:3) The six gates: the horizon is divided into six sectors on each side, east and west, through which the sun moves north and south over the year. Gate 1 is the southernmost (the sun's rising point at midwinter) and gate 6 the northernmost (at midsummer). The sun spends 30 days in each gate, or 31 at the four turning points, making 364.
- c (72:6) The first month: the month beginning at the spring equinox, roughly late March to late April. This calendar starts the year in spring, as in Exod 12:2.
- d (72:10) Parts: the text divides the whole day-and-night into 18 equal parts, so that one part equals 80 minutes. Here the day is 10 parts (13 hours 20 minutes) and the night 8 (10 hours 40 minutes). At the equinoxes each is 9 parts (12 hours); at midsummer the day reaches 12 parts (16 hours) and the night 6 (8 hours). This 2 : 1 ratio of longest to shortest day fits a latitude well north of Judea and was common in Babylonian astronomy.
- e (72:12) Eleven parts: 14 hours 40 minutes; seven parts: 9 hours 20 minutes.
- f (72:13) Because of its sign: the extra 31st day marks a turning point of the year, here the summer solstice, about June 21.
- g (72:20) The autumn equinox, about September 22: day and night are each 12 hours.
- h (72:26) The winter solstice, about December 21: night 16 hours, day 8 hours.
- i (72:32) The spring equinox, about March 20, completing the year: 30 + 30 + 31 days in each of four quarters = 364 days.
- j (72:34) The sense of this verse is obscure in the manuscripts.

- k (72:35) Sixty times: perhaps meaning the sun passes through each pair of gates twice a year, once going north and once going south (6 × 2 × 5?), or the figure is corrupt. Its meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 73

[1] After this law I saw another law, concerning the lesser light, called the moon. [2] Its circle is like the circle of heaven, and the chariot on which it rides is driven by the wind, and light is given to it by measure. [3] Its rising and setting shift every month, and its days are like the days of the sun. When its light is complete, it is a seventh of the sun's light. [4] This is how it rises. Its first phase comes out in the east on the thirtieth morning. On that day it becomes visible and marks for you the start of the month on the thirtieth day, together with the sun, in the gate where the sun rises. [5] Half of it stands out by a seventh, and its whole disk is empty, without light, except for a seventh of it, a fourteenth part of its light.[a] [6] When it receives a seventh of half its light, its light comes to a seventh and a half. [7] It sets with the sun. When the sun rises, the moon rises with it and receives half of one part of light. On that night, at the beginning of its day, the moon sets with the sun and is unseen that night, with its fourteen and a half parts. [8] On that day it rises with exactly a seventh, comes out and moves away from the sunrise, and in its remaining days it grows bright in the other thirteen parts.

Notes

- a (73:5) The moon's light is counted in fourteenths (or sevenths and their halves). Over 14 or 15 days it gains its light in steps and loses it again in the same steps.

Chapter 74

[1] I saw another course and law for the moon, how by that law it makes its monthly circuit. [2] Uriel, the holy angel who leads them all, showed me all of this and their positions. I recorded where they stood just as he pointed them out, and recorded their months as they are and how their light appears, until fifteen days are completed. [3] By sevenths it completes all its light in the east, and by sevenths it completes all its darkness in the west. [4] In certain months it shifts its settings, and in certain months it follows a course of its own. [5] For two months the

moon and sun go down together through the two middle gates, the third and the fourth. [6] It goes out for seven days, turns, and comes back again through the gate where the sun rises and completes all its light. Then it moves away from the sun and in eight days enters the sixth gate, from which the sun comes out. [7] When the sun comes out of the fourth gate, the moon goes out for seven days until it comes out of the fifth, then turns back again in seven days to the fourth gate and completes all its light; then it moves away and enters the first gate in eight days. [8] It comes back again in seven days to the fourth gate, from which the sun comes out. [9] That is how I saw them placed: the rising of the moons and the setting of the sun during those days. [10] If five years are added together, the sun has a surplus of thirty days; and all the days that fall to it for one of those five years, when they are complete, come to 364 days. [11] The surplus of the sun and the stars comes to six days: in five years, at six days a year, that makes thirty days, and the moon falls behind the sun and the stars by thirty days.[a] [12] Sun and stars usher in every year precisely, so that their position never moves ahead or falls behind by a single day, forever; they complete the years with perfect fairness in 364 days. [13] In three years there are 1,092 days, and in five years 1,820 days, so that in eight years there are 2,912 days.[b] [14] For the moon alone the days in three years come to 1,062, and in five years it falls fifty days behind.[c] [15] In five years there are 1,770 days, so that for the moon the days in eight years come to 2,832. [16] In eight years it falls behind by eighty days; all the days it falls behind in eight years are eighty.[d] [17] The year is completed exactly according to their stations in the world and the stations of the sun, which rise from the gates through which it rises and sets for thirty days.

Notes

- a (74:11) The lunar year of twelve months of 29 or 30 days is 354 days, ten days shorter than the 364-day solar year; the text here rounds the yearly difference to six days by a different reckoning, and the figures in verses 10–16 do not all agree. The manuscripts vary in the numbers.
- b (74:13) 3 × 364 = 1,092; 5 × 364 = 1,820; 8 × 364 = 2,912.
- c (74:14) 3 × 354 = 1,062, thirty days short of the solar total; in five years 1,770, fifty short.

- d (74:16) 2,912 − 2,832 = 80.

Chapter 75

1 The leaders of the chiefs of thousands, who are placed over all creation and over all the stars, are also bound up with the four added days.[a] They cannot be separated from their posts, according to the reckoning of the year, and they serve on the four days that are not counted in the reckoning of the year. 2 Because of them people go wrong, for those lights truly serve at the stations of the world: one in the first gate, one in the third gate of heaven, one in the fourth gate, and one in the sixth gate. The year is completed exactly through its 364 separate stations.[b] 3 For Uriel the angel showed me the signs, the seasons, the years, and the days—Uriel, whom the Lord of glory has set forever over all the lights of heaven, in heaven and in the world, so that they may rule over the face of the sky and be seen on the earth and be leaders of the day and the night: the sun, the moon, the stars, and all the serving creatures that make their circuit in all the chariots of heaven.[c] 4 Likewise Uriel showed me twelve doors open in the circle of the sun's chariot in the sky, through which the sun's rays break out. From them warmth spreads over the earth when they are opened at their appointed times; 5 They serve also the winds and the spirit of dew, when they open, standing wide at the edges of the heavens. 6 As for the twelve gates of the sky at the earth's edges: from them the sun, moon, and stars and everything made in the heavens come forth, eastward and westward. 7 Many windows are open to their left and right, and one window at its time sends out warmth, matching those doors from which the stars come out as he has commanded them, and in which they set according to their number. 8 I saw chariots in the sky running through the world above those gates, in which turn the stars that never set. 9 One is larger than all the rest, and it makes its circuit through the whole world.[d]

Notes

- a (75:1) The four added days: the four 31st days, one at the end of each quarter (the equinoxes and solstices), which bring 360 up to 364.
- b (75:2) People go wrong: the author attacks those who used a 360-day year or a lunar calendar; compare 82:4–6 and Jubilees 6:32–38.

- c (75:3) Compare Gen 1:14–18.
- d (75:9) One is larger: perhaps the Great Bear (the Big Dipper), which never sets at northern latitudes; compare "the Bear" in Job 9:9; 38:32.

Chapter 76

1 At the ends of the earth I saw twelve gates open toward all the quarters, from which the winds come out and blow over the earth. 2 Three of them open on the face of the sky, three toward the west, three on the right of the sky, and three on the left.[a] 3 The first three are those of the east, then three of the north, then three of the south, and three of the west. 4 Through four of them come winds of blessing and well-being, and from the other eight come harmful winds. When these are sent, they bring destruction on the whole earth, on the water on it, on all who live on it, and on everything in the water and on the land.

5 The first wind from those gates, called the east wind, comes out through the first gate in the east, the one leaning toward the south. From it come desolation, drought, heat, and ruin. 6 Through the second gate, in the middle, comes what is right: from it come rain, fruitfulness, well-being, and dew. Through the third gate, toward the north, come cold and drought. 7 After these come the south winds, through three gates. Through the first of them, leaning toward the east, a hot wind comes out. 8 Through the middle gate next to it come sweet smells, dew and rain, well-being and health. 9 Through the third gate, toward the west, come dew and rain, locusts and desolation. 10 After these come the north winds. From the seventh gate, on the east side, come dew and rain, locusts and desolation. 11 From the middle gate come, straight on, health and rain, dew and well-being. Through the third gate, on the west side, come mist and frost, snow and rain, dew and locusts. 12 After these four come the west winds. Through the first gate, next to the north, come dew and frost, cold, snow, and ice. 13 From the middle gate come dew and rain, well-being and blessing. Through the last gate, next to the south, come drought and desolation, burning and ruin. 14 So the twelve gates of the four quarters of heaven are finished. All their laws, all their plagues, and all their benefits I have shown you, my son Methuselah.[b]

Notes

- a (76:2) The face of the sky: the east. In Semitic orientation one faces east, so "right" is south and "left" is north.
- b (76:14) *Methuselah*: Hebrew *Metushelaḥ*, perhaps "man of the javelin" or "man of Shelah." Enoch's son (Gen 5:21–27), to whom the Astronomical Book and the Epistle are addressed.

Chapter 77

1 The east is named as the first quarter, since it comes first.[a] The second is called the south, because the Most High will come down there; there especially the one who is blessed forever will come down. 2 The west quarter is called "the waning," because there all the lights of heaven wane and go down. 3 The fourth quarter, called the north, is divided into three: the first part is for human habitation; the second holds seas of water, the deeps, forests, rivers, darkness, and mist; and the third part holds the garden of righteousness.

4 I saw seven high mountains, higher than all the mountains on the earth; from there frost comes out, and days, seasons, and years pass away. 5 I saw seven rivers on the earth, larger than all other rivers. One of them comes from the west and pours its waters into the Great Sea.[b] 6 Two flow down from the north and empty into the Red Sea in the east. 7 The other four come out on the north side to their own sea: two of them to the Red Sea, and two into the Great Sea, where they empty; some say, into the desert. 8 I saw seven great islands in the sea and on the land: two on the land and five in the Great Sea.[c]

Notes

- a (77:1) The quarter names are wordplays in Aramaic or Hebrew: east, *qedem*, also means "first, before"; south, *darom*, is explained as *dar rum*, "the Exalted One dwells," here "the Most High will descend there"; west, *maʿarav*, is linked with *ʿarav*, "to go down, wane"; north, *tsafon*, with *tsafun*, "hidden."
- b (77:5) The Great Sea: the Mediterranean. *The Red Sea*: the *Erythraean Sea*, the waters south and east of Arabia (see the note at 32:2). The rivers may be the Nile, Tigris, Euphrates, and others known to ancient geographers.
- c (77:8) Charles counts this as 77:8; some editions number it 77:9.

Chapter 78

1 These are the names of the sun: the first Oryares, and the second Tomas.[a] 2 The moon has four names: the first is Asonya, the second

Ebla, the third Benase, and the fourth Erae. [3] These are the two great lights. Their circle is like the circle of heaven, and the two circles are the same size. [4] In the circle of the sun there are seven portions of light more than in the moon, and these are passed on in fixed amounts until the seventh portion of the sun is used up. [5] They set and go into the western gates, make their circuit by way of the north, and come out through the eastern gates on the face of the sky. [6] When the moon rises, a fourteenth part appears in the sky, and on the fourteenth day it completes its light. [7] Fifteen parts of light are passed to it until the fifteenth day, when its light is completed according to the sign of the year; it becomes fifteen parts, and the moon grows by fourteenths. [8] As it wanes it loses one part a day: fourteen parts remain after day one, thirteen after day two, then twelve, eleven, ten, nine, eight, seven, six, five, four, three, and two by day thirteen; by day fourteen only half a seventh is left, and by day fifteen the last of its light is gone. [9] Some months last twenty-nine days, and one lasts twenty-eight. [10] Uriel showed me another law: when light is passed to the moon, and from which side the sun passes it. [11] All the time the moon is growing in its light, it is drawing it to itself while facing the sun, for fourteen days, until it is lit all over and its light is complete in the sky. [12] Its first day bears the name new moon, since light first dawns on it then. [13] It becomes full exactly on the day the sun sets in the west; it rises from the east at night and shines all night long until the sun rises opposite it, and the moon is seen opposite the sun. [14] On the side from which the moon's light comes, it wanes again there until all the light is gone and all the days of the month are finished, and its disk is empty, without light. [15] It makes three months of thirty days, and at its time it makes three months of twenty-nine days each, in which it completes its waning in the first period, in the first gate, for 177 days.[b] [16] As it goes out, it shows itself through three thirty-day months and three twenty-nine-day months. [17] At night it looks like a man for twenty days each time,[c] and by day it looks like the sky, for there is nothing else in it but its light.

Notes

- a (78:1) The names of the sun and moon are of uncertain origin. *Oryares* may come from Hebrew *ʾor ḥeres*, “light of the sun”; *Tomas* perhaps from Hebrew *ḥammah*, “heat,” or Aramaic. Of the moon’s names, *Asonya*, *Ebla*, *Benase*, and *Erae* may reflect Hebrew *ʾishon*, “pupil (of the eye),” *levanah*, “white one,” *ben ḥese*, “son of the full moon,” and *yareaḥ*, “moon.” All are guesses.
- b (78:15) 177 days: 3 × 30 + 3 × 29 = 177, half of a lunar year of 354 days.
- c (78:17) Like a man: perhaps the “man in the moon”; the text is uncertain.

Chapter 79

1 Now, my son, I have shown you everything, and the law of all the
stars of heaven is complete. 2 He showed me all their laws for every
day, for every season of rule, for every year and its going out, and for
the order set for it every month and every week; 3 and the waning
of the moon that takes place in the sixth gate, for in this sixth gate
its light is completed, and after that the waning begins; 4 and the
waning that takes place in the first gate in its season, until 177 days
are completed, which, counted in weeks, are twenty-five weeks and
two days.[a] 5 It falls behind the sun and the order of the stars by exactly
five days in the course of one period,[b] when this place that you see
has been passed through. 6 This is the picture and outline of every
light, which Uriel the archangel, their leader, showed me.

Notes

- a (79:4) 25 × 7 + 2 = 177.
- b (79:5) One period: half a year; 182 − 177 = 5. Compare 74:10–16.

Chapter 80

1 At that time Uriel the angel spoke to me in reply: “Look, Enoch, I
have shown you everything. I have revealed everything to you, so
that you may behold the sun and the moon, the guides of heaven’s
stars, and all who turn them, their tasks, their times, and their depar-
tures.

2 But in the days of the sinners the years will be cut short;
their seed will be late on their land and in their fields;
everything on the earth will change
and will not appear at its proper time.
The rain will be held back,
and the sky will withhold it.

3 In those times the fruit of the earth will be late
and will not grow at its proper time,
and the fruit of the trees will be held back in its season.
4 The moon will change its order
and will not appear at its time.
5 In those days the sun will be seen, and it will travel in the evening at the edge of the great chariot in the west,
and will shine more brightly than the order of light allows.
6 Many chiefs of the stars will break the order,
will change their circuits and their tasks,
and will not appear at the times set for them.
7 The whole order of the stars will be hidden from the sinners,
and the thoughts of those on the earth will go wrong about them;
they will turn away from all their ways,
they will err and take them for gods.
8 Evil will multiply upon them,
and punishment will come on them
to destroy them all."

Chapter 81

1 He said to me,
"Look, Enoch, at these heavenly tablets;[a]
read what is written on them,
and take note of every single thing."
2 I looked at the heavenly tablets and read everything written there and understood it all. I read the book of all human deeds and of all mortals who will be on the earth to the farthest generations.
3 At once I blessed the great Lord, the King of glory forever, for having made all the works of the world.
I praised the Lord for his patience,
and blessed him on account of the children of humankind.
4 After that I said,
"Happy is the one who dies in righteousness and goodness,
about whom no book of wrongdoing has been written
and against whom no day of judgment will be found."

5 Those seven holy ones[b] brought me and set me on the earth in front of the door of my house, and said to me, "Tell everything to your son Methuselah, and show all your children that no human being is righteous before the Lord, for he is the one who made them.
6 We will leave you with your son for one year, until you give your instructions, so that you may teach your children, write things down for them, and bear witness to all your children. In the second year they will take you from among them.[c]
7 Let your heart be strong,
for the good will announce righteousness to the good;
the righteous will rejoice with the righteous
and congratulate one another.
8 But sinners will die with sinners,
and the apostate will go down with the apostate.
9 Those who do right will die because of human deeds
and be gathered in because of the deeds of the wicked."
10 Then they stopped speaking with me, and I went back among my people, praising the Lord of the world.

Notes

- a (81:1) The heavenly tablets: a heavenly record of all that will happen and of God's laws, prominent also in Jubilees (for example 3:10; 5:13). Compare Ps 139:16; Dan 10:21.
- b (81:5) Those seven holy ones: the seven archangels of 20:1–8.
- c (81:6) Compare 82:1 and chapters 91 and 106–107, where Enoch instructs Methuselah.

Chapter 82

1 Now, my son Methuselah, I am telling you all these things and writing them down for you. I have revealed everything to you and given you books about all of them. So keep safe, my son Methuselah, the books from your father's hand, and pass them on to the generations of the world.
2 I have given wisdom to you and your children,
and to the children you will have,
so that they in turn hand it on to their own children through the

generations,
a wisdom past their understanding.
3 Those who understand it will not sleep,
but will keep their ears open to learn this wisdom,
and it will please those who eat it more than fine food.
4 Happy are all the righteous! Happy are all who walk in the way of righteousness and do not sin as the sinners do in counting all their days, the days in which the sun crosses the sky, going in and out of each gate for thirty days alongside the chiefs of thousands who order the stars, and with the four extra days that split the year into quarters, which guide them and go in with them on those four days. 5 Because of these, people will go wrong and will not count them in the full reckoning of the year; they will go wrong and not recognize them accurately. 6 They are part of the year's count and stand written truly forever: in gates one, three, four, and six, one day apiece, so that the year is filled out at 364 days. 7 Its account is accurate and its recorded reckoning exact, for Uriel showed me and revealed to me the lights, the months, the festivals, the years, and the days—Uriel, to whom the Lord of all the creation of the world has subjected the host of heaven. 8 He has authority over night and day in heaven, to make the light shine on human beings: sun, moon, and stars, and all the powers of heaven that turn in their circling chariots.
9 Here are the ranks of the stars that go down each in its place, its season, its festival, and its month. 10 Here also are the names of their guides, who see to it that each comes in on time, by rank and season and month, in its term of rule and its station. 11 First come in the four leaders who split the year into quarters; next the twelve rank-leaders who apportion the months; then, for the 360 days, chiefs of thousands who apportion the days; and for the four extra days, leaders who mark off the quarters. 12 These chiefs of thousands are slotted in between one leader and the next, each following a station, while the leaders themselves do the dividing. 13 These are the names of the leaders who divide the four appointed parts of the year: Milkiel, Helemmelek, Meleyal, and Narel.[a] 14 Their guides are named Adnarel, Iyasusael, and Elomeel. These three come after the rank-leaders, and

one more comes after those three, who in turn come after the station-leaders that mark off the quarters of the year. 15 At the beginning of the year Melkeyal rises first and rules; he is called Tamaini and "sun." All the days of his rule while he governs are ninety-one days.[b] 16 These are the signs of the days to be seen on earth in the days of his rule: sweat, heat, and calm. All the trees bear fruit and put out leaves; the wheat is harvested; the roses bloom, and all the flowers that come up in the field; but the trees of winter wither.[c] 17 These are the names of the leaders under them: Berkael, Zelebsel, and another chief of a thousand who is added, called Hiluyaseph. And the days of this one's rule are ended. 18 The next leader after him is Helemmelek, whom they call "the shining sun." All the days of his light are ninety-one days.[d] 19 These are the signs of his days on the earth: scorching heat and dryness. The trees ripen their fruit and bring all their fruit to ripeness and readiness; the sheep mate and conceive; all the fruit of the earth is gathered in, and everything in the fields, and the winepress. These things happen in the days of his rule. 20 These are the names, the orders, and the leaders of those chiefs of thousands: Gidaiyal, Keel, and Heel, and the name of the chief of a thousand added to them is Asfael. And the days of his rule are ended.[e]

Notes

- a (82:13) *Milkiel*: "my king is God." *Helemmelek*: perhaps "the king's companion" or "the king is strong." *Meleyal*: "fullness of God." *Narel*: "light of God" or "fire of God." The names of the lesser leaders are of uncertain meaning.
- b (82:15) Ninety-one days: one quarter of the 364-day year. Beginning at the spring equinox, this first quarter runs roughly from late March to late June.
- c (82:16) The wheat harvest in the land of Israel falls in May–June.
- d (82:18) The second quarter, roughly late June to late September.
- e (82:20) The book breaks off here; the leaders of the third and fourth quarters are not given.

Chapter 83

The Book of Dreams (chapters 83–90)

1 Now, my son Methuselah, I will show you all the visions I have seen, telling them to you one by one.[a] 2 I saw two visions before I married, and they were quite unlike each other. The first came while I was

learning to write; the second, before I married your mother, was a fearful vision. About them I prayed to the Lord. [3] I had lain down to sleep at my grandfather Mahalalel's house[b] and in a vision I watched the sky give way, torn loose and falling onto the earth. [4] As it fell on the earth, I saw the earth swallowed in a vast abyss. Mountains hung upon mountains, hills sank down onto hills, and tall trees were ripped from their trunks, flung down, and sunk in the abyss. [5] Then a word came into my mouth, and I raised my voice and cried out, "The earth is destroyed!" [6] My grandfather Mahalalel, who was lying near me, woke me and asked, "Why are you crying out like this, my son? Why such wailing?" [7] I told him the whole vision I had seen, and he said to me, "You have seen something terrible, my son. Your dream vision is grave; it concerns the secrets of all the earth's sin. The earth must sink into the abyss and be utterly destroyed. [8] Now, my son, get up and plead with the Lord of glory, since you are a man of faith, that a remnant may be left on the earth and that he may not wipe out the whole earth. [9] My son, all this will come down on the earth from heaven, and there will be vast destruction on the earth." [10] After that I got up and prayed, pleaded, and begged, and I wrote down my prayer for the generations of the world. I will show it all to you, my son Methuselah. [11] When I had gone outside and seen the sky, the sun coming up in the east, the moon going down in the west, a scattering of stars, the whole earth, and all things just as he had known them from the start, I blessed the Lord of judgment and praised him, because he had made the sun come out of the windows of the east, so that it climbed and rose over the face of the sky and set out and went on along the path appointed for it.

Notes

- a (83:1) The Book of Dreams (chapters 83–90) contains two dream visions. Aramaic fragments of it are reported from Qumran (4QEn c–f), and it is usually dated to about 165–160 BC, during the Maccabean revolt, because the Animal Apocalypse (chapters 85–90) ends its review of history around that time.
- b (83:3) *Mahalalel*: Hebrew *Mahalal'el*, "praise of God." Enoch's great-grandfather in Gen 5:12–18 (Mahalalel, Jared, Enoch); the Ethiopic here calls him grandfather.

Chapter 84

1 Lifting my hands in righteousness, I blessed the Holy and Great One.
I spoke using my mouth's breath and the fleshly tongue that God
made for human beings to speak with; he gave them breath, a tongue,
and a mouth to speak with:

2 "Blessed are you, Lord, King,
great and mighty in your greatness,
Lord of all the creation of heaven,
King of kings and God of the whole world!
Your power, your kingship, and your greatness last forever and
ever,
and your rule through all generations.
All the heavens are your throne forever,
and the whole earth your footstool forever and ever.[a]

3 For you made all things and you rule all things;
nothing is too hard for you.
Wisdom never leaves the place of your throne
or turns away from your presence.
You know, see, and hear everything,
and nothing is hidden from you, for you see everything.

4 Now the angels of your heavens have done wrong,
and your anger rests on human flesh
until the great day of judgment.

5 Now, God and Lord and great King,
I beg and plead with you to grant my prayer:
leave me descendants on the earth;
do not destroy all human flesh
and empty the earth of people,
making the destruction permanent.

6 Now, my Lord, remove from the earth the flesh that has roused your
anger,
but establish the flesh of righteousness and uprightness
as a plant of eternal seed.[b]
Do not hide your face from your servant's prayer, Lord."

Notes

- a (84:2) Compare Isa 66:1.
- b (84:6) A plant of eternal seed: compare "the plant of righteousness" at 10:16 and 93:2, 5, 10, an image for the faithful remnant of Israel.

Chapter 85

1 Later I had a second dream, and I will tell you all of it, my son. 2 Enoch raised his voice and spoke to his son Methuselah: "I will speak to you, my son. Hear my words, and turn your ear to your father's dream vision.[a] 3 Before I married your mother Edna,[b] I saw in a vision on my bed: there was a bull coming out of the earth, and that bull was white.[c] After it came a young cow, and with her came two bulls, one black and the other red. 4 The black bull gored the red one and chased him across the earth, and after that I could no longer see the red bull. 5 But the black bull grew, and that young cow went with him. I saw many cattle come from him, looking like him and following him. 6 That cow, the first one, left the first bull to look for the red one, but did not find him. She mourned bitterly over him and kept searching. 7 I watched until the first bull came to her and calmed her, and from then on she cried no more. 8 Next she gave birth to a second white bull,[d] and then to many bulls and black cows. 9 In my sleep I saw that white bull also grow and become a great white bull, and many white bulls came from him that looked like him. 10 They began to father many white bulls like themselves, one after another, a great many.

Notes

- a (85:2) Chapters 85–90 are known as the Animal Apocalypse. They retell history from Adam to the end time in symbols: the patriarchs before Jacob are bulls (white for the righteous line, black for the wicked); fallen angels are stars; Israel are sheep; the nations are wild beasts and birds of prey; and angels appear as men. The notes identify each figure as most scholars read it.
- b (85:3) *Edna*: perhaps "delight" (Hebrew *'ednah*). Enoch's wife, not named in Genesis; Jubilees 4:20 also calls her Edna.
- c (85:3) The white bull is Adam; the heifer is Eve; the black and red bulls are Cain and Abel.
- d (85:8) Another white bull: Seth (Gen 4:25).

Chapter 86

1 Again, as I slept, I looked with my eyes and saw the sky above,
and there a star fell from heaven,[a] and it got up, ate, and grazed
among those cattle. 2 After that I saw the large black cattle, and they
all changed their stalls, their pastures, and their herds, and began to
live together.[b] 3 Again I looked in the vision toward the sky, and I
saw many stars come down and throw themselves from heaven to
that first star. They became bulls among those cattle and grazed with
them.[c] 4 I looked at them and saw that they all exposed their organs
like stallions and began to mount the cows of the cattle. They all
became pregnant and gave birth to elephants, camels, and donkeys.[d]
5 All the cattle were afraid of them and terrified, and began to bite
with their teeth, to devour, and to gore with their horns. 6 They even
began to devour those cattle, and all the children of the earth began
to shake and tremble before them and run away from them.

Notes

- a (86:1) A star: the first fallen angel, probably Asael (Azazel), compare 88:1 and 10:4.
- b (86:2) The line of Seth (white) and the line of Cain (black) mingle.
- c (86:3) The Watchers come down (chapter 6; Gen 6:1–4).
- d (86:4) The giants, in three kinds, compare 7:2 and the note there.

Chapter 87

1 Again I saw how they began to gore one another and devour one
another, and the earth began to cry out. 2 I raised my eyes to heaven
again and saw in the vision beings coming out of heaven who looked
like white men.[a] Four came out from that place, and three with them.
3 The three who came out last took me by the hand and carried me
off, far from the earth's generations, up to a lofty place. They showed
me a tower rising high above the earth, with all the hills lower than
it. 4 One of them said to me, "Stay here until you see everything that
happens to those elephants, camels, and donkeys, and to the stars and
the cattle, all of them."

Notes

- a (87:2) Like white men: angels. The four are the archangels of chapter 10 (Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Sariel or Phanuel); the three with them are other angels who take Enoch up.

Chapter 88

1 I saw one of the four who had come out first seize that first star
which had fallen from heaven. He tied it hand and foot and threw it
into an abyss; that abyss was narrow and deep, dreadful and dark.[a] 2
Another of them unsheathed a sword and handed it to the elephants,
camels, and donkeys, and they began to strike one another, and the
whole earth shook because of them.[b] 3 As I watched in the vision,
one of the four who had come out threw stones down from heaven,
gathered and took all the great stars whose organs were like stallions',
tied them all hand and foot, and threw them into an abyss of the earth.

Notes

- a (88:1) Compare 10:4–5, where Raphael binds Asael and casts him into darkness.
- b (88:2) Compare 10:9–12.

Chapter 89

1 One of those four went to that white bull[a] and taught him a secret,
without his being afraid. He had been born a bull and became a
man. He built himself a great vessel and lived on it, and three bulls
lived with him in that vessel, and they were shut in. 2 Again I raised
my eyes toward heaven and saw a high roof with seven streams of
water on it, and those streams poured a great deal of water into an
enclosure. 3 I looked again, and springs opened on the floor of that
great enclosure, and the water began to swell and rise over the floor. I
watched that enclosure until its whole floor was covered with water.
4 Water, darkness, and mist grew over it. When I looked at how high
the water was, it had risen above the height of the enclosure and
was pouring over it, and it stood on the earth. 5 All the cattle of that
enclosure were herded together until I saw them sink, swallowed up,
and die in that water. 6 But the vessel floated on the water, while all
the cattle, elephants, camels, and donkeys sank to the bottom with all
the animals. I could no longer see them; they could not get away, but
died and sank into the depths. 7 Again I watched in the vision until
those streams were taken away from that high roof, the chasms of the
earth were leveled, and other abysses were opened. 8 Then the water
began to drain into these until the earth could be seen. The vessel

came to rest on the earth, the darkness withdrew, and light appeared.
9 That white bull who had become a man came out of the vessel, and
the three bulls with him. One of the three was white like that bull, one
was red as blood, and one was black. And that white bull left them.[b]
10 They began to produce wild animals and birds, so that there
came to be different kinds: lions, leopards, wolves, dogs, hyenas,
wild boars, foxes, badgers, pigs, falcons, vultures, kites, eagles, and
ravens. Among them a white bull was born.[c] 11 They began to bite one
another. But the white bull born among them fathered a wild donkey
and a white bull with it, and the wild donkeys multiplied.[d] 12 The bull
born from him fathered a black wild boar and a white sheep. The
boar fathered many boars, but the sheep fathered twelve sheep.[e] 13
When those twelve sheep had grown, they handed one of them over
to the donkeys, and the donkeys in turn handed that sheep over to
the wolves, and that sheep grew up among the wolves.[f] 14 The Lord
brought the other eleven to share its home and pasture among the
wolves, and they increased into many flocks. 15 The wolves began to
fear them and oppressed them, even destroying their little ones; they
threw their young into a river full of water.[g] But the sheep began to
cry out over their little ones and to complain to their Lord. 16 A sheep
that had been rescued from the wolves fled and escaped to the wild
donkeys.[h] I saw the sheep mourning and crying out, pleading with
their Lord with all their strength, until the Lord of the sheep came
down from a lofty dwelling at the sheep's cry and came to them and
shepherded them. 17 He called the sheep that had escaped the wolves
and spoke with it about the wolves, that it should warn them not to
touch the sheep. 18 The sheep went to the wolves as the Lord had said,
and another sheep met it and went with it.[i] The two went together
into the gathering of those wolves and spoke with them, warning
them not to touch the sheep from then on. 19 After that I saw the
wolves oppress the sheep harshly with all their might, and the sheep
cried out. 20 The Lord came to the sheep, and they began to strike
those wolves.[j] The wolves began to wail, but the sheep grew quiet and
at once stopped crying out. 21 I watched the sheep until they left the
wolves behind. But the wolves' eyes were blinded, and they set out

after the sheep with all their might. 22 The Lord of the sheep led the
way, with his whole flock behind him. His face was dazzling, glorious,
and fearful to look at. 23 But the wolves began to chase those sheep
until they reached a sea of water. 24 That sea was split, and the water
stood on one side and the other in front of them. Their Lord went at
their head and stood between the flock and the wolves.[k] 25 Since the
wolves did not yet see the sheep, they went into the middle of that
sea; the wolves followed the sheep and ran after them into the sea.
26 When they saw the Lord of the sheep, they turned to run from his
face, but the sea came back together and became as it had been made;
the water swelled and rose until it covered those wolves. 27 I watched
until all the wolves chasing those sheep had died and drowned.
28 The sheep, however, came safely out of the water into a desert
without water or pasture, and there their eyes started to open so
that they could see.[l] I saw the Lord of the sheep shepherding them,
providing water and pasture, while that sheep went ahead as their
guide. 29 That sheep went up to the top of that high rock,[m] and the
Lord of the sheep sent it to them. 30 After that I saw the Lord of the
sheep standing in front of them. His appearance was great, fearful,
and majestic; all those sheep saw him and were afraid before his face.
31 They were all afraid and trembled because of him, and they cried
out to the sheep that was with them, “We cannot stand before our
Lord or look at him.”[n] 32 The sheep that led them went up again to the
top of that rock. Meanwhile the flock grew blind and strayed from
the path it had shown them, and that sheep did not know it.[o] 33 The
Lord of the sheep was very angry with them. That sheep found out,
came down from the top of the rock, came to the sheep, and found
most of them blinded and gone astray. 34 When they saw it, they were
afraid and trembled before it, and wanted to go back to their folds.
35 That sheep took other sheep with it, came to the sheep that had
strayed, and began to kill them,[p] and the sheep were afraid of it. So
that sheep brought back the strayed sheep, and they returned to their
folds. 36 In this vision I kept watching until that sheep turned into a
man, constructed a house for the Lord of the sheep, and settled the
whole flock in it.[q] 37 I watched until the sheep that had met the sheep

who led them fell asleep.[r] I watched until all the great sheep died
and young ones took their place; these reached a pasture and drew
near a stream.[s] 38 Then that sheep, their leader who had become a
man, parted from them and fell asleep, and all the sheep looked for it
and wept over it bitterly.[t] 39 I watched until they stopped weeping for
that sheep and crossed that stream of water. Then two sheep arose
as leaders in place of those who had led them and fallen asleep.[u] 40 I
watched until the sheep came to a good place, a pleasant and glorious
land, and I watched until those sheep were satisfied; and that house
stood among them in the pleasant land.
41 Sometimes their eyes were opened and sometimes blinded, until
another sheep rose up to lead them and turned them all back, and
their eyes came open.[v] 42 The dogs, foxes, and wild boars began to
devour those sheep, until the Lord of the sheep raised up a ram from
among them to lead them.[w] 43 That ram began to butt those dogs,
foxes, and wild boars on every side, until he had destroyed them all. 44
That sheep whose eyes were opened saw that ram among the sheep,
until it abandoned its glory and began to butt those sheep, trample
them, and behave disgracefully. 45 The Lord of the sheep sent the lamb
to another lamb, to make it a ram and leader of the sheep in place
of the ram that had abandoned its glory.[x] 46 It went to it, spoke with
it privately, and made it a ram, prince and leader of the sheep; but
through all this those dogs were oppressing the sheep. 47 The first ram
chased that second ram, and the second ram got up and fled from it.
I watched until those dogs brought down the first ram.[y] 48 The second
ram then took the lead of the young sheep. 49 The flock increased
greatly, while every dog, foxes, and wild boars were afraid and fled
from it. The ram gored the wild beasts to death, and they had no
more power among the sheep and robbed them of nothing. This ram
had many offspring and then died, and a young sheep took its place
as ram and became prince and leader of those sheep.[z] 50 That house
became large and wide, and it was built for those sheep. On the house
rose a great high tower for the Lord of the sheep.[aa] The house was
low, but the tower was raised high, and the Lord of the sheep took
his stand upon it, and a full table was laid before him.

51 Again I saw those sheep going astray and walking in many
paths and abandoning that house of theirs. The Lord of the sheep
summoned some of the flock and sent them to the rest, who set about
killing them.[ab] 52 One of them was saved and not killed. It hurried away
and cried out over the sheep, and they tried to kill it, but the Lord of
the sheep rescued it from them, lifted it up to where I was, and settled
it there.[ac] 53 He sent many other sheep to those sheep to testify to them
and lament over them. 54 After that I saw that when they abandoned
the house of the Lord and his tower, they fell away completely and
their eyes were blinded. I saw the Lord of the sheep carry out great
slaughter among them in their flocks, until those sheep brought on
that slaughter themselves and betrayed his place. 55 He handed them
over to the lions and leopards, the wolves and hyenas, the foxes, and
all the wild beasts, and those wild beasts began to tear those sheep
apart. 56 I saw that he abandoned that house of theirs and their tower
and gave them all over to the lions to tear and devour them, to all the
wild beasts. 57 I began to cry out with all my strength and appeal to
the Lord of the sheep, pleading with him about the sheep, that they
were being devoured by all the wild beasts. 58 But he stayed silent,
though he saw it, and was glad that they were devoured, swallowed,
and robbed, and left them to be devoured by all the beasts.
59 He called seventy shepherds[ad] and threw those sheep to them to
pasture them. He said to the shepherds and their companions, "From
now on, each of you is to pasture the sheep, and do everything I
command you. 60 I will hand them over to you counted, and tell you
which of them are to be destroyed; destroy those." And he handed
those sheep over to them. 61 He called another and said to him, "Watch
and note everything the shepherds do to these sheep, for they will kill
more of them than my orders allow.[ae] 62 Write down every excess and
destruction the shepherds carry out: how many they destroy at my
command and how many on their own whim. Record against each
shepherd all the destruction he causes. 63 Read me the tally of those
they kill and those they give up to be killed, so that it may stand as
evidence against them and I may know all the shepherds' actions and
judge their conduct, whether they keep the command I gave them. 64

But they must not know it. Do not tell them or warn them, but simply record against each one all the destruction the shepherds cause, each in his time, and bring it all up to me." 65 I watched until those shepherds pastured in their season, and they began to kill and destroy more than they had been told, and they handed those sheep over to the lions. 66 The lions and leopards ate and devoured most of those sheep, with the wild boars sharing the meal; and they burned that tower and tore down that house.[af] 67 I grieved deeply over that tower, because the house of the sheep had been torn down, and afterward I could not see whether those sheep went into that house.

68 The shepherds and their companions handed those sheep over to all the wild beasts to devour them, and each of them received a set number in his time. The other wrote in a book how many of them each one destroyed. 69 Each one killed and destroyed far more than was allotted, and I began to weep and mourn over those sheep. 70 So in the vision I saw the one who wrote: how he wrote down each one destroyed by those shepherds, day by day, and carried the whole book up, laid it down, and showed it to the Lord of the sheep—everything they had done, all that each of them had done away with, and all they had handed over to destruction. 71 It was read aloud to the Lord of the sheep; then he took it from the writer, read it himself, sealed it, and set it aside.

72 Right away I saw the shepherds pasture for twelve hours.[ag] Three of those sheep turned back, came and went in, and began to rebuild everything of that house that had fallen down;[ah] the wild boars tried to stop them but could not.[ai] 73 They began to build again as before, and they raised up that tower, and it was called the high tower. Once more they laid a table in front of the tower, yet every loaf on it was polluted and unclean.[aj] 74 Through all this the flock's eyes were sightless, and so were their shepherds'. Great numbers were handed to the shepherds to be destroyed, who stamped on them and ate them up. 75 The Lord of the sheep stayed silent until all the sheep were scattered over the field and mixed with the beasts, and the shepherds did not rescue them from the beasts. 76 The one who wrote the book carried it up, showed it, and read it before the Lord of the sheep. He pleaded

with him on their behalf and begged him for them as he showed him all the shepherds' deeds, and he testified before him against all the shepherds. [77] He took the book itself, laid it down beside him, and left.

Notes

- a (89:1) That white bull: Noah. He is born a bull but becomes a man, perhaps meaning he is taught by angels or set apart; Moses likewise becomes a man in verse 36. The three bulls are Shem, Ham, and Japheth.
- b (89:9) Shem is white (the chosen line); Ham and Japheth are red and black, though which is which is uncertain.
- c (89:10) The wild animals and birds are the nations. Lions, leopards, and others appear later as Israel's oppressors: Egyptians are wolves; Philistines dogs; Edomites wild boars; Ammonites and Moabites foxes; Assyrians lions; Babylonians leopards (or tigers); Greeks eagles and other birds of prey; Seleucid Syrians ravens. *A white bull*: Abraham.
- d (89:11) A wild donkey: Ishmael, called "a wild donkey of a man" in Gen 16:12. *A white bull*: Isaac. The wild donkeys are the Arabs or Midianites.
- e (89:12) The black wild boar: Esau, ancestor of Edom. *The white sheep*: Jacob, whose twelve sons are the twelve sheep. From here on Israel is pictured as sheep.
- f (89:13) Joseph, sold to the Ishmaelites/Midianites and taken to Egypt (Gen 37:25–36).
- g (89:15) Exod 1:8–22.
- h (89:16) Moses, who fled to Midian (Exod 2:15).
- i (89:18) Another sheep: Aaron (Exod 4:27).
- j (89:20) The plagues of Egypt (Exod 7–12).
- k (89:24) Exod 14:19–22.
- l (89:28) Opening and blinding of the eyes is the vision's image for Israel's faithfulness and apostasy.
- m (89:29) Mount Sinai (Exod 19).
- n (89:31) Exod 20:18–19.
- o (89:32) The golden calf (Exod 32).
- p (89:35) The Levites' slaughter in Exod 32:26–28.
- q (89:36) The house: here the tabernacle (Exod 25–40); later it stands for Jerusalem, with the "tower" as the temple.
- r (89:37) Fell asleep: died. Aaron's death (Num 20:28).
- s (89:37) The Jordan.
- t (89:38) The death of Moses (Deut 34).
- u (89:39) Two sheep: perhaps Joshua and Caleb, or Joshua and Eleazar.
- v (89:41) The period of the judges; the other sheep is probably Samuel.
- w (89:42) A ram: Saul, the first king. The dogs are the Philistines; the foxes Ammon and Moab; the boars Edom/Amalek.
- x (89:45) The lamb sent is Samuel; the other lamb is David (1 Sam 16).

- y (89:47) Saul pursues David and dies fighting the Philistines (1 Sam 18–31).
- z (89:49) The last sentence (Charles's 48b) tells of David's death and Solomon's succession; some manuscripts place it after verse 48.
- aa (89:50) The tower: Solomon's temple. The house is now Jerusalem.
- ab (89:51) The prophets, compare 1 Kgs 19:10; Neh 9:26.
- ac (89:52) Elijah, taken up to heaven (2 Kgs 2:11), now dwelling with Enoch.
- ad (89:59) Seventy shepherds: angelic rulers set over Israel from the exile to the end time, each for a fixed period. The number recalls the seventy years of Jer 25:11–12 and the seventy weeks of years of Dan 9:24, and the seventy nations of Gen 10. Their periods fall into four groups of 12, 23, 23, and 12 (89:72; 90:1, 5).
- ae (89:61) Another: a recording angel, perhaps Michael (compare 90:14, 17).
- af (89:66) The Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem and the temple in 587/586 BC, with Edom joining in (Obad 10–14; Ps 137:7).
- ag (89:72) Twelve hours: the periods of twelve shepherds, the Persian era. Each shepherd's term is called an hour.
- ah (89:72) Three sheep: probably Zerubbabel, Jeshua the high priest, and Ezra or Nehemiah (Ezra 3–6; Neh 2–6).
- ai (89:72) The wild boars: here the Samaritans and neighboring peoples who opposed the rebuilding (Ezra 4).
- aj (89:73) The author judges the worship of the second temple to be impure, perhaps over calendar or priestly disputes; compare Mal 1:7.

Chapter 90

1 I watched until thirty-five shepherds had taken up the pasturing in this way,[a] each completing his term as the first ones had; and others took them in hand to pasture them for their term, each shepherd in his own term. 2 Next in my vision every bird of the air came flocking: eagles, vultures, kites, and ravens, with the eagles at the head of them all,[b] and they set upon the sheep, pecking out their eyes and feeding on their flesh. 3 The sheep cried out because the birds were eating their flesh. As for me, I looked on and mourned in my sleep over that shepherd who was pasturing the sheep. 4 I watched until those sheep were devoured by the dogs, eagles, and kites, and they left them no flesh, skin, or sinew, until only their bones were standing; then their bones too fell to the ground, and the sheep became few. 5 I watched until twenty-three had taken up the pasturing and completed, in their terms, fifty-eight periods.[c]

6 But look: lambs were born to those white sheep,[d] and they began to open their eyes and see, and to cry out to the sheep. 7 They cried

out to them, but the sheep did not listen to what they said; they were completely deaf, and their eyes were utterly blinded. 8 I saw in the vision the ravens swoop on those lambs and seize one of them,[e] and tear the sheep to pieces and devour them. 9 I watched until horns grew on those lambs, and the ravens knocked their horns down. Then I watched until a great horn sprouted on one of those sheep,[f] and their eyes were opened. 10 It looked at them, and it cried out to the sheep, and the rams caught sight of it and came running to it together. 11 Still, through all this, those eagles, vultures, ravens, and kites kept tearing the sheep, swooping on them and devouring them. The sheep stayed silent, but the rams mourned and cried out. 12 The ravens fought hard against it, striving to topple its horn, yet they could not prevail. 13 I watched until the shepherds, eagles, vultures, and kites came and called to the ravens to break the horn of that ram. They fought and battled with it, and it fought with them and cried out for its help to come.[g] 14 I kept watching until the man who listed the shepherds' names and took them up to the Lord of the sheep arrived to aid it and revealed all things to it; he had descended to assist that ram.[h] 15 I watched until the Lord of the sheep came to them in anger, and everyone who saw him ran, and all of them collapsed into his shadow away from his presence. 16 All the eagles, vultures, ravens, and kites gathered together, and all the sheep of the field came with them; they all came together and helped one another to break that ram's horn.[i] 17 I watched that man who wrote the book at the Lord's command, until he opened the book about the destruction that the last twelve shepherds had done, and showed before the Lord of the sheep that they had destroyed far more than those before them. 18 I watched until the Lord of the sheep came to them, took in his hand the staff of his anger, and struck the earth. The earth split open, and all the beasts and all the birds of the sky fell away from those sheep and were swallowed up in the earth, and it closed over them. 19 I kept watching until the sheep were handed a mighty sword and marched out against all the beasts of the field to kill them, and all the beasts and birds of the sky fled from before them.

20 I watched until a throne was set up in the pleasant land,[j] and the
Lord of the sheep sat on it, and the other took the sealed books and
opened them before the Lord of the sheep.[k] 21 The Lord called those
men, the first seven white ones,[l] and ordered them to bring before
him all the stars whose organs were like stallions', starting with the
first star that led the way; and they brought them all before him. 22
He said to the man who wrote before him, who was one of those
seven white ones, "Take those seventy shepherds to whom I handed
over the sheep, and who on their own authority took them and killed
more than I commanded." 23 And look, I saw them all bound, and they
all stood before him. 24 Judgment was held first on the stars. Tried
and convicted, they were sent off to the place of sentence; they were
thrown into an abyss full of fire and flame and full of pillars of fire.[m]
25 The seventy shepherds were then tried, convicted, and hurled into
that abyss of fire. 26 At that time I saw a similar abyss opened in the
middle of the earth, full of fire. The blinded sheep were led in, every
one tried and convicted, and cast into this blazing pit, where they
burned. It lay on the right-hand side of the house.[n] 27 I watched the
sheep burn, bones and all.
28 I stood up to look, until they folded up that old house. They carried
off all its pillars, and all the beams and decorations of the house were
folded up with it, and they carried it away and put it in a place in
the south of the land. 29 I kept watching until the Lord of the sheep
brought in a fresh house, bigger and loftier than before, and raised
it where the folded-up one had stood. Every pillar in it was new,
and its adornments were new too, and grander than those of the old
house he had removed. All the sheep were inside it.[o] 30 I saw every
remaining sheep, with every beast of the earth and every bird of the
air, bowing down and paying homage to those sheep, pleading with
them and obeying them in everything.[p] 31 After that, those three who
were dressed in white, who had taken me by the hand and brought
me up before, took me up with the hand of that ram also holding
me, and set me down among those sheep before the judgment took
place.[q] 32 Every one of those sheep was white, with fleece thick and
clean. 33 All that had been destroyed and scattered, along with every

wild beast and every bird of the air, assembled in the house, and the Lord of the sheep was full of joy because they were all good and had come back to his house. 34 I watched until they laid down that sword that had been given to the sheep; they brought it back into the house, and it was sealed in the Lord's presence. All the sheep were invited into that house, but it could not hold them. 35 Every one of them had open eyes and beheld what was good, and there was not one among them who did not see. 36 I saw that the house was large and wide and very full.

37 Then I saw a white bull born, big-horned,[r] and every wild beast and every bird of the air stood in awe of him and made constant petition to him. 38 I watched until all their kinds were transformed and they all became white bulls. The first among them became a lamb,[s] which grew into a mighty creature with huge black horns on its head; and the Lord of the sheep took delight in it and in the whole herd. 39 I slept among them, and I woke up having seen everything. 40 This is the vision I saw while I slept. I woke up and blessed the Lord of righteousness and gave him glory. 41 Then I wept bitterly, and my tears would not stop until I could bear it no longer. When I looked, they ran down because of what I had seen, for everything will come and be fulfilled, and all human deeds in their order were shown to me. 42 On that same night the earlier dream came back to me, and it made me weep and left me shaken, for I had seen that vision."

Notes

- a (90:1) Thirty-five shepherds: 12 of the Persian period plus 23 more, carrying the story into the Greek period after Alexander the Great (332 BC).
- b (90:2) The eagles: the Macedonians/Greeks, probably the Ptolemies of Egypt, who ruled Judea about 301–200 BC. The ravens are the Seleucids of Syria.
- c (90:5) Fifty-eight periods: 12 + 23 + 23 shepherds, leaving the last 12 for the final age (90:17).
- d (90:6) The lambs: a reform movement among pious Jews in the early second century BC, perhaps the group behind this book or the Hasidim of 1 Macc 2:42.
- e (90:8) One of those lambs: probably the high priest Onias III, murdered about 171 BC (2 Macc 4:33–35; compare Dan 9:26).
- f (90:9) A great horn: Judas Maccabeus, leader of the Jewish revolt against the Seleucid king Antiochus IV from 166 BC (1 Macc 3–9). The vision's history ends with his struggles, which dates it to about 164–160 BC.

- g (90:13) Verses 13–15 and 16–18 seem to be two versions of the same scene; Charles rearranged them (13, 16, 19 then 14, 15, 17, 18). This translation keeps the manuscript order.
- h (90:14) That man: the recording angel of 89:61, often taken as Michael, who in 2 Macc 11:6–8 sends a heavenly rider to aid Judas.
- i (90:16) The sheep of the field: probably wild sheep, that is, the Hellenizing Jews who sided with the Seleucids.
- j (90:20) The pleasant land: the land of Israel (compare Dan 8:9; 11:16).
- k (90:20) Compare Dan 7:9–10.
- l (90:21) The first seven white ones: the seven archangels (20:1–8; compare 87:2).
- m (90:24) Compare 18:11; 21:7–10.
- n (90:26) To the right: south of Jerusalem, the Valley of Hinnom (Gehenna); compare 27:1–3.
- o (90:29) The new house: a new Jerusalem built by God himself; compare Isa 54:11–12; Ezek 40–48; Rev 21:2. Notably no tower (temple) is mentioned.
- p (90:30) Compare Isa 49:23; 60:14.
- q (90:31) Before the judgment: the order is odd; some read "before the judgment" as "after." The ram may be Elijah, here pictured as a ram, who returns before the end (Mal 4:5); compare 89:52.
- r (90:37) A white bull: a messianic figure. Humanity returns to the condition of Adam (the first white bull, 85:3), and all the nations become white bulls.
- s (90:38) A lamb: the Ethiopic word *nagar* ("word," or a corruption) is unclear; Charles emended to "wild ox" (Hebrew *re'em*), others keep "lamb." This translation follows the common reading "lamb," noting the uncertainty.

Chapter 91

The Epistle of Enoch (chapters 91–108)

1 "Now, my son Methuselah, call all your brothers to me,
and gather to me all the sons of your mother;
for a word calls me,
and the spirit is poured out on me,
so that I may show you everything
that will happen to you forever."[a]

2 Then Methuselah went and called all his brothers to him and gathered his relatives.

3 He spoke to all the children of righteousness and said,
"Hear, you sons of Enoch, all your father's words,
and listen well to the voice of my mouth.

I urge you and tell you, beloved:
love uprightness and walk in it.
4 Do not come near uprightness with a divided heart,
and do not keep company with the double-hearted,
but walk in righteousness, my sons.
It will guide you on good paths,
and righteousness will go with you.
5 For I know that violence will grow strong on the earth,
and a great punishment will be carried out on the earth;
all wrongdoing will come to an end,
cut off at its roots,
and its whole building torn down.[b]
6 Wrongdoing will again reach its full measure on the earth,
and all deeds of wrongdoing, violence,
and transgression will prevail twice over.
7 When sin, wrongdoing, blasphemy,
and violence in every kind of deed increase,
and apostasy, transgression, and impurity increase,
a great punishment will come from heaven on all these,
and the holy Lord will come out in anger and punishment
to carry out judgment on the earth.
8 In those days violence will be cut off at its roots,
and the roots of wrongdoing together with deceit,
and they will be destroyed from under heaven.
9 All the idols of the nations will be given up,
their temples burned with fire,
and they will be removed from the whole earth.
The nations will be thrown into the judgment of fire
and perish in anger and in harsh judgment forever.
10 The righteous will rise from their sleep,
and wisdom will rise and be given to them.
11 After that the roots of wrongdoing will be cut off, and the sinners will be destroyed by the sword … will be severed from the blasphemers everywhere; schemers of violence and speakers of blasphemy alike will fall by the sword.[c]

12 After that there will be another week, the eighth, the week of righteousness,[d]
and a sword will be given to it,
so that righteous judgment may be carried out on the oppressors,
and sinners will be handed over to the righteous.
13 At its end they will gain houses through their righteousness,
and a house will be built for the Great King in glory forever.[e]
14 After that, in the ninth week,
righteous judgment will be revealed to the whole world;
all the works of the wicked will vanish from the whole earth,
the world will be written down for destruction,
and all humankind will look to the path of uprightness.
15 After this, in the tenth week, in its seventh part,
there will be the great eternal judgment,
in which he will take vengeance among the angels.
16 The first heaven will depart and pass away,
and a new heaven will appear,[f]
and all the powers of the heavens will shine seven times as bright forever.
17 After that there will be many weeks without number, forever,
in goodness and righteousness,
and sin will never again be mentioned.
18 So now, my sons, I am telling you and pointing out to you
which roads lead to righteousness and which to violence.
I will show them to you again,
so that you may know what will happen.
19 Listen to me now, my sons:
keep to the roads of righteousness
and keep off the roads of violence;
for everyone who travels the roads of wrongdoing will perish forever."

Notes

- a (91:1) Chapters 91–108 make up the final section of 1 Enoch: Enoch's instruction to his children (91), the Apocalypse of Weeks (93:1–10 with 91:11–17), and the Epistle proper (92; 94–105), followed by the Birth of Noah (106–107) and a closing

appendix (108). The Aramaic fragments (4QEn g) and the Greek Chester Beatty papyrus (for 97:6–107:3) are reported to support most of it; it is usually dated to the second century BC. In the Ethiopic manuscripts the order is disturbed: the last three "weeks" (91:12–17) stand before the first seven (93:3–10). The Aramaic is reported to have them in sequence, and many translations rearrange them; this translation keeps the Ethiopic order and numbering, and the notes point to the sequence.

- b (91:5) The first end: the flood.
- c (91:11) The text of this verse is damaged; the gap is marked by an ellipsis.
- d (91:12) The eighth week: in the sequence of the Apocalypse of Weeks this follows 93:10. Each "week" is an age of world history; the author probably lived in the seventh, the time of the "apostate generation" (93:9) in the early second century BC.
- e (91:13) A house … for the Great King: a new temple. *The Great King*: God (compare Ps 48:2; Matt 5:35).
- f (91:16) Compare Isa 65:17; 66:22; 2 Pet 3:13; Rev 21:1.

Chapter 92

1 The book written by Enoch—Enoch wrote this complete teaching of wisdom, praised by everyone and judge of the whole earth—for every child of mine who will dwell on the earth, and for the generations to come who will practice uprightness and peace.[a]

2 Do not let your spirit be troubled because of the times,
for the Holy and Great One has set days for everything.

3 The righteous one will rise from sleep;
he will rise and walk the ways of righteousness,
and his whole way and conduct will be in eternal goodness and grace.

4 He will be gracious to the righteous one and give him lasting uprightness,
and give him power, so that he will have goodness and righteousness
and walk in eternal light.

5 Sin will perish in darkness forever
and will not be seen again from that day on, forever.

Notes

- a (92:1) This verse is the heading of the Epistle of Enoch proper; the bracketed words in Charles ("Enoch indeed wrote … all the earth") may be a scribe's addition.

Chapter 93

1 Afterward Enoch handed on the books and began to tell from them.
2 Enoch said,
"About the children of righteousness,
about the chosen of the world,
and about the plant of uprightness,[a] I will speak these things;
I, Enoch, will declare them to you, my sons,
according to what appeared to me in the heavenly vision,
what I learned from the word of the holy angels,
and what I came to understand from the heavenly tablets."
3 Enoch began to tell from the books and said,
"I came into the world seventh, in the first week,[b]
while judgment and righteousness still lasted.
4 After me, in the second week, great wickedness will arise,
and deceit will have sprung up.
In it will be the first end,[c]
and in it a man will be saved.
After it is over, wrongdoing will grow,
and a law will be made for the sinners.
5 After that, at the end of the third week,
a man will be chosen as the plant of righteous judgment,[d]
and his descendants will become the plant of righteousness forever.
6 After that, at the end of the fourth week,
visions of the holy and righteous will be seen,
and a law for all generations, and an enclosure, will be made for them.[e]
7 After that, at the end of the fifth week,
the house of glory and dominion will be built forever.[f]
8 After that, in the sixth week, all who live in it will be blinded,
and the hearts of all of them will godlessly abandon wisdom.
In it a man will go up,[g]
and at its end the house of dominion will be burned with fire,
and the whole race of the chosen root will be scattered.

9 After that, in the seventh week, an apostate generation will arise;
its deeds will be many,
and all its deeds will be apostate.
10 At its end the chosen righteous
from the eternal plant of righteousness will be chosen
to receive sevenfold instruction about all his creation.[h]
11 For who is there among all humankind who can hear the voice of the Holy One without being shaken? Who can think his thoughts? Who is there who can look on all the works of heaven?[i] 12 How could anyone look at heaven? Who could grasp heavenly things, or see a soul or spirit and report on it, or go up and see all their ends and grasp them or act like them? 13 Who among all people could know how wide and how long the earth is, and to whom has the measure of all of them been shown? 14 Or is there anyone who could tell the length of heaven, how great its height is, what it rests on, how many stars there are, and where all the lights rest?

Notes

- a (93:2) The plant of uprightness (or righteousness): Israel, or the faithful within it; compare 10:16; 84:6; Isa 60:21; 61:3.
- b (93:3) The seventh: Enoch is the seventh from Adam (Gen 5; Jude 14).
- c (93:4) The first end: the flood. *A man*: Noah. *A law … for the sinners*: the laws given after the flood (Gen 9:1–7).
- d (93:5) A man: Abraham. His descendants, Israel, are "the plant of righteousness."
- e (93:6) The law of Sinai and the tabernacle (or the land of Israel as an "enclosure").
- f (93:7) The temple of Solomon.
- g (93:8) A man: Elijah (2 Kgs 2:11). *The house of dominion … burned*: the destruction of the temple in 587/586 BC and the exile.
- h (93:10) The sequence continues at 91:11–17 (weeks eight to ten).
- i (93:11) Verses 11–14 are a separate wisdom poem on the limits of human knowledge, compare Job 38; Isa 40:12–14; Sir 1:2–3. Its rhetorical questions contrast with Enoch, who has been shown these things.

Chapter 94

1 Now I tell you, my sons: love righteousness and walk in it;
for the paths of righteousness deserve to be welcomed,
but the paths of wrongdoing will suddenly be destroyed and vanish.

2 To certain people of a generation the paths of violence and of death will be revealed,
and they will keep far from them
and not follow them.
3 Now I tell you, the righteous:
do not walk in the path of evil or in the paths of death,
and do not come near them, so that you are not destroyed.
4 But seek and choose for yourselves righteousness and a chosen life,
and walk in the paths of peace,
and you will live and prosper.
5 Hold on to my words in the thoughts of your hearts,
and do not let them be wiped from your hearts;
for I know that sinners will tempt people to mistreat wisdom,
so that no place will be found for her,
and temptation of every kind will not lessen.
6 Woe to those who build wrongdoing and oppression
and lay deceit as a foundation;
for they will suddenly be overthrown,
and they will have no peace.[a]
7 Woe to those who build their houses with sin;
for they will be overthrown from all their foundations
and fall by the sword.
Those who get gold and silver in judgment will suddenly perish.
8 Woe to you, the rich, for you have trusted in your riches;
from your riches you will depart,
because you did not remember the Most High in the days of your wealth.
9 You have committed blasphemy and wrongdoing
and have made yourselves ready for the day of slaughter,
the day of darkness and the day of the great judgment.
10 So I tell you and declare to you:
the one who created you will overthrow you,
and there will be no pity at your fall,
and your Creator will rejoice at your destruction.

11 In those days your righteous ones will be
a rebuke to the sinners and the wicked.

Notes

- a (94:6) The woes (94:6–100:9; 103:5–8) attack wealthy oppressors and apostates, in the style of the prophets (Isa 5:8–23; Amos 6:1–7) and of Luke 6:24–26.

Chapter 95

1 If only my eyes were a cloud of water,
so that I might weep over you
and pour down my tears like rain from a cloud,
and so find rest from my heart's distress!
2 Who has allowed you to practice insult and wickedness?
Judgment will catch up with you, sinners.
3 Do not fear the sinners, you righteous;
for the Lord will again hand them over to you,
so that you may carry out judgment on them as you wish.
4 Woe to you who pronounce curses that cannot be undone;
healing will be far from you because of your sins.
5 Woe to you who repay your neighbor with evil;
for you will be repaid according to your deeds.
6 Woe to you, lying witnesses,
and those who weigh out injustice,
for you will suddenly perish.
7 Woe to you, sinners, for you persecute the righteous;
for you yourselves will be handed over and persecuted, you people of injustice,
and its yoke will be heavy on you.

Chapter 96

1 Take hope, you righteous! For the sinners will suddenly perish before you,
and you will rule over them as you wish.
2 On the day of the sinners' distress
your children will soar and rise like eagles;
your nest will be higher than the vultures'.

You will climb up and go into the crevices of the earth
and the clefts of the rock forever, like rock badgers, away from the unjust,
and the sirens will sigh and weep because of you.[a]
3 So do not be afraid, you who have suffered;
for healing will be your share,
a bright light will shine on you,
and you will hear the voice of rest from heaven.
4 Woe to you, sinners, for your riches make you look like the righteous,
yet your own hearts expose you as sinners,
and that will testify against you, a reminder of your evil deeds.
5 Woe to you who eat the finest wheat
and drink wine from large bowls,[b]
and trample the lowly with your strength.
6 Woe to you who drink water from every spring,
for you will suddenly be consumed and wither away,
because you have abandoned the spring of life.[c]
7 Woe to you who practice wrongdoing,
deceit, and blasphemy;
it will be a reminder against you for evil.
8 Woe to you, the mighty,
who use your might to oppress the righteous;
for your day of ruin is on its way.
Then many good days will come to the righteous, on the day of your judgment.

Notes

- a (96:2) Rock badgers: the hyrax, a small animal that shelters in rocks (Ps 104:18; Prov 30:26). *The sirens*: the Ethiopic borrows the Greek *seirēnes*, which the Greek Bible uses for desert creatures (perhaps ostriches or jackals) in Isa 13:21. The verse is obscure and some think it is out of place.
- b (96:5) Compare Amos 6:6.
- c (96:6) Compare Jer 2:13.

Chapter 97

1 Believe, you righteous, that the sinners will be put to shame
and perish on the day of wrongdoing.
2 Know, you sinners, that the Most High has your destruction in mind,
and the angels of heaven rejoice over your destruction.
3 What will you do, you sinners,
and where will you run on that day of judgment,
when you hear the sound of the prayer of the righteous?
4 You will fare like those
against whom this word will stand as evidence:
"You have been companions of sinners."
5 At that time the righteous will pray and be heard by the Lord,
and your time of judgment will arrive.
6 All the words of your wrongdoing will be read out before the Great Holy One;
your faces will be covered with shame,
and he will reject every work grounded in wrongdoing.[a]
7 Woe to you, sinners, who live in the middle of the sea and on the dry land;
the memory of you is evil against you.
8 Woe to you who get silver and gold unjustly and say,
"We have grown rich and have possessions,
and have gotten everything we wanted.
9 Now let us do what we have planned;
for we have stored up silver,
our barns are full to the brim, as if with water,
and many are the farmhands in our houses."[b]
10 Your lies will flow away like water,
for your wealth will not last
but will quickly fly up from you;
because you got it all unjustly,
you will be handed over to a great curse.

Notes

- a (97:6) From 97:6 to 107:3 a Greek text survives in the Chester Beatty–Michigan papyrus (fourth century AD). Where it differs from the Ethiopic in meaning, the notes say so.
- b (97:9) Compare Luke 12:16–21.

Chapter 98

1 Now I swear to you, the wise and the foolish,
that you will see many things on the earth.
2 You men will put on more finery than a woman
and more colors than a young girl;
in royalty, grandeur, and power,
in silver, gold, and purple,
in splendor and in food you will be poured out like water.
3 So they will lack teaching and wisdom,
and through this they will perish along with their possessions;
with all their glory and splendor,
in shame, slaughter, and great poverty,
their spirits will be thrown into the furnace of fire.
4 I have sworn to you, sinners: no mountain was ever made a slave,
no hill made a woman's maid,
so sin was not sent onto the earth;
people created it themselves,[a]
and those who commit it will fall under a great curse.
5 Barrenness was not given to woman;
because of the deeds of her own hands she dies childless.[b]
6 By the Holy Great One I swear to you, sinners,
that every evil thing you do lies open in heaven,
and none of your oppressive deeds are covered or hidden.
7 Do not think in your spirit or say in your heart that you do not know and do not see that every sin is recorded every day in heaven before the Most High.
8 From now on you know that all the oppression you inflict is written down every day until the day of your judgment.
9 Woe to you, fools, for you will perish through your folly. You sin against the wise, and so good fortune will not be your share.

10 Now know that you are ready for the day of destruction. Do not
hope to live, sinners; you will go away and die, for you know no
ransom. You are made ready for the day of the great judgment, for
the day of distress and great shame for your spirits.
11 Woe to you, stubborn of heart, who do evil and eat blood![c] Where
do you get good things to eat and drink and be full? From all the good
things the Lord Most High has placed in abundance on the earth. So
you will have no peace.
12 Woe to you who love deeds of wrongdoing! Why do you hope for
good fortune for yourselves? Know that you will be handed over to
the righteous, and they will cut off your necks and kill you and show
you no mercy.
13 Woe to you who rejoice at the distress of the righteous, for no grave
will be dug for you.
14 Woe to you who treat the words of the righteous as nothing, for you
will have no hope of life.
15 Woe to you who write down lying and wicked words; for they write
down their lies so that people will hear them and act wickedly toward
their neighbor.[d]
16 So they will have no peace but will die a sudden death.

Notes

- a (98:4) Sin was not sent: the Epistle insists on human responsibility for sin, in tension with the Book of the Watchers, which traces evil to the fallen angels (chapters 6–16).
- b (98:5) The meaning is uncertain; the sense may be that suffering comes from human deeds, not from God's decree.
- c (98:11) Eat blood: forbidden in Gen 9:4; Lev 17:10–14.
- d (98:15) Perhaps aimed at rival teachers or writings; compare 104:10–11.

Chapter 99

1 Woe to you who act wickedly
and take pride in lies and praise them;
you will perish, and no happy life will be yours.
2 Woe to those who twist the words of uprightness
and break the eternal law,

and make themselves into what they were not, into sinners;
they will be trampled on the earth.
3 In those days, you righteous, get ready to raise your prayers as a reminder
and set them as evidence before the angels,
so that they may set the sin of the sinners as a reminder before the Most High.
4 In those days the nations will be stirred up,
and the families of the nations will rise on the day of destruction.
5 In those days the destitute will go out and carry off their children
and abandon them, so that their children perish because of them;
they will abandon their nursing infants and not return to them,
and will have no pity on their loved ones.
6 Again I swear to you, sinners, that sin is made ready for a day of unending bloodshed.
7 Those who worship stones, and carved images of gold, silver, wood, stone, and clay, and those who worship unclean spirits and demons and all kinds of idols in ignorance, will get no help at all from them.
8 They will become wicked through the folly of their hearts,
and their eyes will be blinded by the fear of their hearts
and by visions in their dreams.
9 Through these they will become wicked and afraid,
for they will have done all their work in a lie
and worshiped a stone;
so in an instant they will perish.
10 But in those days, happy is everyone who takes wisdom's words to heart and grasps them,
who keeps to the Most High's ways and follows his righteous road,
and do not become wicked with the wicked;
for they will be saved.
11 Woe to you who spread evil to your neighbors;
for you will be killed in Sheol.[a]
12 Woe to you who make false and deceitful measures,
and to those who cause bitterness on the earth;
for by this they will be completely consumed.

13 Woe to you who build your houses through others' hard labor,
whose every brick and stone is made of sin;
I assure you, you will have no peace.
14 Woe to those who reject the measure and eternal inheritance of their ancestors,
whose souls follow idols;
for they will have no rest.
15 Woe to those who do wrong and help oppression,
and kill their neighbors, until the day of the great judgment.
16 For he will throw down your glory,
bring affliction on your hearts,
rouse his fierce anger,
and put every one of you to the sword;
and the holy and righteous, all of them, will recall your sins.

Notes

- a (99:11) *Sheol*: Hebrew *she'ol*, the realm of the dead; compare 22:1–14.

Chapter 100

1 In those days fathers will be struck down together with their sons in one place,
and brothers will fall dead one with another,
until the streams run with their blood.
2 For a man will not hold back his hand from killing his sons and grandsons,
and the sinner will not hold back his hand from his honored brother;
from dawn to sunset they will kill one another.
3 The horse will wade up to its chest in the blood of sinners,
and the chariot will sink to its top.[a]
4 In those days the angels will come down into the hidden places
and gather in one place all who brought down sin,
and the Most High will rise on that day of judgment
to carry out great judgment among sinners.
5 Over all the righteous and holy he will appoint guardians from among the holy angels,

to guard them like the pupil of an eye,[b]
until he puts an end to all wickedness and all sin;
and even if the righteous sleep a long sleep, they have nothing to fear.

6 Then the children of the earth will see the wise in safety
and grasp everything this book says,
and realize that wealth cannot save them
when their sins bring them down.

7 Woe to you, sinners, on the day of fierce anguish,
you who afflict the righteous and burn them with fire;
you will be repaid according to your deeds.

8 Woe to you, stubborn of heart,
who stay awake to plan wickedness;
fear will come on you,
and there will be no one to help you.

9 Woe to you, sinners, because of the words of your mouth
and the deeds of your hands that your wickedness has done;
you will burn in blazing flames worse than fire.

10 Now know that he will ask the angels in heaven about your deeds, and the sun, the moon, and the stars about your sins, because on the earth you pass judgment on the righteous.

11 He will call every cloud, mist, dew, and rain to testify against you; for they will all be held back because of you from coming down on you, and they will remember your sins.

12 Now go ahead and give gifts to the rain so that it will not be held back from coming down on you, or to the dew, if it has accepted gold and silver from you to come down![c]

13 When frost and snow with their cold, and all the snowstorms with all their plagues, fall on you, in those days you will not be able to stand before them.

Notes

- a (100:3) Compare Rev 14:20.
- b (100:5) Like the pupil of an eye: traditionally "the apple of the eye"; compare Deut 32:10; Ps 17:8.

- c (100:12) Irony: the rich cannot bribe the weather. The Greek is reported to differ here.

Chapter 101

1 Look at the sky, you children of heaven, and at every work of the
Most High; fear him and do no evil in his presence. 2 If he shuts the
windows of heaven and holds back the rain and the dew from falling
on the earth because of you, what will you do then? 3 If he sends his
anger on you because of your deeds, you cannot plead with him, for
you spoke proud and arrogant words against his righteousness. So
you will have no peace. 4 Do you not see the sailors on ships, how
their vessels are tossed about by the waves and shaken by the winds,
and are in great danger? 5 They are afraid because all their valuable
goods go out on the sea with them, and their hearts dread that the
sea will swallow them and they will die in it. 6 Are not the whole sea
and all its waters and all its motion the work of the Most High? Has
he not set limits to what it does and hemmed it in on every side with
sand?[a] 7 When he rebukes it, it takes fright and dries up, and every
fish in it perishes, together with all that it holds. Yet you sinners who
live on the land have no fear of him. 8 Is it not he who formed heaven
and earth and whatever fills them? Who gave insight and wisdom to
every creature that moves over the land and through the sea? 9 Do
not the sailors fear the sea? Yet sinners do not fear the Most High.

Notes

- a (101:6) Compare Job 38:8–11; Jer 5:22.

Chapter 102

1 In those days, when he brings a terrible fire on you,
where will you run, and where will you find rescue?
When he hurls his word against you,
will you not be shaken and afraid?
2 All the lights will be shaken with great fear,
and all the earth will be shaken and tremble in alarm.
3 All the angels will carry out their orders
and try to hide from the presence of the Great Glory,
and the children of the earth will tremble and shake.

You sinners will be cursed forever,
and you will have no peace.
4 Do not be afraid, you souls of the righteous;
take hope, you who have died in righteousness.
5 Do not grieve if your soul has gone down to Sheol in grief,
and your body did not fare in life as your goodness deserved;
but wait for the day of the sinners' judgment,
the day of cursing and punishment.
6 Yet when you die, the sinners say over you,
"As we die, so the righteous die,
and what good have they gained from their deeds?
7 Look, they die just as we do, in grief and darkness;
what more do they have than we?
From now on we are equal.
8 What will they receive, and what will they see forever?
Look, they too have died,
and from now on they will never see light."[a]
9 I tell you, sinners: you are content to eat and drink, to rob and sin, to strip people naked, to get wealth and see good days.
10 Have you seen how the righteous end, that no violence of any kind is found in them until they die?
11 "Still, they perished and became as though they had never been, and their spirits went down to Sheol in distress."

Notes

- a (102:8) The sinners' argument recalls Eccl 2:14–16; 3:19–21; Wis 2:1–5.

Chapter 103

1 And now I make this vow to you, the righteous, by the splendor of the Great One, the Honored and Powerful, who rules, and by his majesty I vow it to you:
2 I know a mystery;
I have read the heavenly tablets
and seen the holy books,
and I have found written and engraved in them about them:

3 every blessing, joy and glory has been made ready for them
and recorded for the spirits of those who have died in righteousness;
your reward for your hard work will be a rich share of good things,
and your portion is far better than the portion of those still alive.
4 The spirits of you who have died in righteousness will live and rejoice;
their spirits will not perish, nor their memory before the face of the Great One,
for all the generations of the world.
So do not fear their scorn any longer.
5 Woe to you, sinners, when you have died,
if you die in the wealth of your sins,
and those like you say of you,
"Happy are the sinners! They have seen all their days.
6 Now they have died in prosperity and wealth,
and have seen no distress or killing in their life;
they have died in honor,
and no judgment was carried out on them while they lived."
7 Know that their souls will be brought down to Sheol,
and they will be wretched in their great distress.
8 Your spirits will pass into darkness, into fetters and a blazing flame, where the judgment is severe;
and the great judgment will last through every generation of the world.
Woe to you, for you will find no peace.
9 Do not say of the righteous and good who are alive,
"In our troubled days we have worked hard and known every trouble;
we have met much evil and been worn out,
and have become few and small in spirit.
10 We were ruined, and nobody came to our aid, not even with a word;
we were tormented and crushed, and we gave up expecting to see another day of life.

11 We had hoped to be the head, and we turned out to be the tail;[a]
we labored and strained and gained no satisfaction from our labor;
we became a meal for sinners and the lawless,
and they pressed their yoke hard upon us.
12 Those who hated us and struck us have ruled over us,
and we bowed our necks to those who hated us,
but they had no pity on us.
13 We wanted to get away from them, to escape and rest,
but found no place to run to and be safe from them.
14 We complained to the rulers in our distress
and cried out against those who devoured us,
but they paid no attention to our cries
and would not listen to our voice.
15 They helped those who robbed us, devoured us, and made us few. They hid their oppression and did not remove from us the yoke of those who devoured us, scattered us, and murdered us. They hid their murders and did not remember that they had raised their hands against us."[b]

Notes

- a (103:11) Compare Deut 28:13, 44.
- b (103:15) Verses 9–15 voice the complaint of the righteous; the answer follows in chapter 104.

Chapter 104

1 I vow to you that the angels in heaven keep you in mind for good in the presence of the Great One's glory, and that your names are inscribed there before him.[a] 2 Take hope! For before, you were put to shame through evil and affliction, but now you will shine like the lights of heaven; you will shine and be seen, and the gates of heaven will be opened to you.[b] 3 When you cry out, let your cry be for justice, and justice will show itself to you; for all you have suffered will be avenged upon the rulers and upon everyone who aided your plunderers. 4 Take hope, and do not throw away your hope; for you will have great joy like the angels of heaven. 5 What will you have to do? You will not have to hide on the day of the great judgment,

you will not be found as sinners, and the eternal judgment will be far from you for all the generations of the world. 6 Now do not be afraid, you righteous, when you see the sinners growing strong and prospering in their ways. Do not keep company with them, but keep far from their violence; for you will become companions of the hosts of heaven. 7 Though you sinners say, "None of our sins will be searched out and written down," still they will write down all your sins every day. 8 Now I tell you that light and darkness, day and night, both look upon all your sins. 9 Do not be wicked in your hearts; do not lie or alter the words of uprightness, or call the words of the Holy Great One lies, or pay attention to your idols; for all your lying and all your wickedness lead not to righteousness but to great sin. 10 Now I know this mystery: sinners will alter and twist the words of righteousness in many ways; they will speak wicked words, lie, practice great deceptions, and write books about their own words. 11 But if they copy out my words faithfully into their own languages, neither altering them nor cutting anything away, but setting down faithfully everything that I first declared about them,[c] 12 then I know another mystery: books will be given to the righteous and the wise, to be a source of joy, uprightness, and much wisdom. 13 The books will be given to them, and they will believe them and rejoice over them; and then all the righteous who have learned from them all the paths of uprightness will be rewarded.

Notes

- a (104:1) Compare Dan 12:1; Luke 10:20.
- b (104:2) Compare Dan 12:3.
- c (104:11) This passage, with its concern for faithful copying and translation "in their languages," is notable in a work that itself survives mainly in translation. Compare Rev 22:18–19.

Chapter 105

1 In those days, says the Lord, they will call to the children of the earth and testify about their wisdom: "Show it to them, for you are their guides, and rewards over the whole earth. 2 For I and my son will be joined with them forever in the paths of uprightness in their lives. You will have peace. Rejoice, you children of uprightness!" Amen.[a]

Notes

- a (105:2) I and my son: the phrase is unusual; it may refer to God and the righteous (or Israel) as his son, or be a Christian touch. The Greek papyrus is reported to lack this chapter.

Chapter 106

The Birth of Noah (chapters 106–107)

1 Some days later my son Methuselah chose a wife for his son Lamech, and she conceived and bore him a son.[a] 2 The child's body was as white as snow and as ruddy as a rose in blossom; the hair on his head and his long locks were white like wool, and his eyes were lovely. When he opened his eyes, the whole house filled with light, as if the sun were shining in it. 3 Then he stood up in the hands of the midwife, opened his mouth, and spoke with the Lord of righteousness. 4 Lamech, his father, was terrified of him and ran away to his own father, Methuselah. 5 He said to him, "I have fathered a strange son, different from and unlike a human being, resembling the children of the God of heaven. His nature is different; he is not like us. His eyes are like the rays of the sun, and his face is glorious. 6 I think he cannot have come from me, but from the angels, and I fear that something extraordinary will happen on earth in his time. 7 Now, my father, I am here to plead with you and beg you to go to Enoch, our father, and learn the truth from him, for he lives among the angels." 8 When Methuselah heard what his son said, he traveled to the ends of the earth to find me, for he had been told that I was there. He called out, and I heard his voice and went to him. I said to him, "I am here, my son. Why have you come to me?" 9 He answered, "I have come to you because of something that worries me greatly, a troubling sight. 10 Now, my father, hear me. A son has been born to my son Lamech, unlike anyone else. His nature is not like a human nature. The color of his body is whiter than snow and redder than a rose in bloom, the hair of his head is whiter than white wool, his eyes are like the rays of the sun, and when he opened his eyes he lit up the whole house. 11 He rose up from the midwife's hands, opened his mouth, and praised the Lord of heaven. 12 His father Lamech became afraid and fled to me. He does not believe that the boy is his, but that

he is in the likeness of the angels of heaven. So I have come to you so that you may tell me the truth." [13] I, Enoch, replied, "The Lord is going to do something new on earth. I have seen it before in a vision, and I am telling you now: in the days of my father Jared, certain angels of heaven disobeyed the Lord's command.[b] [14] They sin and break the law; they have joined themselves to women and sin with them, have married some of them, and have fathered children by them. [15] A great destruction will come over the whole earth; there will be a flood and great destruction for one year.[c] [16] This son who has been born to you will be left on the earth, and his three children will be saved with him; when all humankind on the earth dies, he and his sons will be saved. [17] They will produce giants on the earth, not of spirit but of flesh, and there will be great punishment on the earth, and the earth will be cleansed of all impurity.[d] [18] Now tell your son Lamech that the one who has been born is truly his son. Name him Noah, for he will be left to you, and he and his sons will be saved from the destruction that will come on the earth because of all the sin and all the wrongdoing that will reach its full measure on the earth in his days.[e] [19] After that, injustice will grow greater still than the injustice that had at first reached its full measure on earth. For I know the mysteries of the holy ones: the Lord himself has revealed them to me and explained them, and I have read them on the heavenly tablets.

Notes

- a (106:1) Chapters 106–107 tell of Noah's miraculous birth, a story also found in the Genesis Apocryphon from Qumran (1QapGen 2–5). *Lamech*: Hebrew *Lemekh*, of uncertain meaning (Gen 5:25–31).
- b (106:13) *Jared*: Hebrew *Yered*, "descent," explained in 6:6 as the time when the Watchers came down.
- c (106:15) For one year: the flood lasts a year and ten days in Gen 7:11; 8:14 (or a full year by the 364-day calendar).
- d (106:17) Charles moves verse 17 before 15 for sense; this translation keeps the usual numbering.
- e (106:18) *Noah*: Hebrew *Noaḥ*, linked with *nuaḥ*, "rest," and *niḥam*, "comfort" (Gen 5:29); compare 107:3.

Chapter 107

1 I saw written on them that generation after generation will do
wrong, until a generation of righteousness arises, wrongdoing is
destroyed, sin passes away from the earth, and every kind of good
comes on it. 2 Now, my son, go and tell your son Lamech that this
son who has been born is truly his son, and that this is no lie." 3
When Methuselah heard the words of his father Enoch—for Enoch
had disclosed everything to him in secret—he went back and reported
them to Lamech, and the boy was named Noah, because he will bring
comfort to the earth after all that destruction.

Chapter 108

Another Book of Enoch (chapter 108)

1 Here is a further book that Enoch composed for his son Methuselah
and for the people who will follow him and observe the law in the last
days.[a] 2 You who have done good, wait for those days, until an end is
made of those who do evil and of the power of the lawbreakers. 3 Wait
until sin has passed away, for their names will be erased from the
book of life and from the holy books; their offspring will be destroyed
forever, and their spirits will be killed. They will cry out and mourn
in a place that is a formless wasteland, and they will burn in the
fire, for there is no earth there.[b] 4 There I saw a kind of cloud that I
could not see through; it was so deep that I could not see over it. I
saw a flame blazing brightly, and shining mountainlike shapes that
wheeled and swung back and forth. 5 I asked one of the holy angels
who accompanied me, "What is this glowing thing? It is no heaven,
only the flame of a blazing fire, with a sound of weeping and crying,
of lament and fierce pain." 6 He said to me, "This place you see is
where the spirits of sinners and blasphemers are thrown, and of those
who do evil, and of those who twist everything the Lord has spoken
through the mouth of the prophets about the things to come. 7 Some
of these matters are written and engraved up in heaven, so that the
angels can read them and learn what lies ahead for the sinners, and
for the spirits of the humble, and for those who mortified their bodies
and were repaid by God, and for those who were shamed by wicked

people: [8] those who loved God, and cared nothing for gold or silver or any of the good things of the world, but surrendered their bodies to torture; [9] who from the time they came into being did not crave earthly food, but counted everything as a passing breath and lived that way; and the Lord tested them often, and their spirits were found pure, so that they might bless his name. [10] I have recounted in the books all the blessings meant for them. He has assigned them their reward, because they have been found to love heaven more than their life in the world. Though they were trampled by wicked people, and suffered abuse and insult from them and were put to shame, still they blessed me.[c] [11] And now I will call forth the spirits of the good people of the generation of light, and I will transform those born in darkness, who were given no honor in the flesh to match their faithfulness. [12] I will lead them out into radiant light, those who loved my holy name, and I will set each of them on his throne of honor. [13] They will shine for times without number; for righteousness is God's judgment, and to the faithful he will give faithfulness in the dwelling of upright paths. [14] They will watch the ones born in darkness being thrown into darkness, even as the righteous shine out. [15] The sinners will cry out as they see them shining, and they will go where days and times are set for them."

Notes

- a (108:1) Chapter 108 is a late appendix, found only in Ethiopic; nothing of it is reported among the Aramaic fragments.
- b (108:3) The book of life: compare 47:3; Exod 32:32–33; Ps 69:28; Rev 20:12–15.
- c (108:10) Me: the speaker shifts from the angel to God himself in verses 10–13.

Jubilees

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

God's Words to Moses on Mount Sinai

1 In the first year after the Israelites left Egypt, on the sixteenth day
of the third month,[a] God said to Moses, "Come up to me on the
mountain. I will give you the two stone tablets of the law and the
commandment, which I have written so that you may teach them."[b]
2 So Moses went up the mountain of God, and the glory of the Lord
settled on Mount Sinai, and a cloud covered it for six days. 3 On
the seventh day he called Moses out of the cloud, and the sight of
the Lord's glory on the mountaintop was like a blazing fire. 4 Moses
stayed on the mountain forty days and forty nights, and God showed
him the history of all the days of the law and the testimony, from the
earliest times to the latest.[c] 5 He said, "Set your heart on every word
I speak to you on this mountain, and write them in a book, so that
their descendants may see that I never abandoned them, however
much evil they did by breaking the covenant that I am making today
between me and you on Mount Sinai, for all their generations. 6 When
all these things have come upon them, they will recognize that I am
more just than they in every judgment and in every act, and that I
was truly with them. 7 You must write down for yourself all the words
that I tell you today. I know how rebellious and stubborn they are,
even before I bring them into the land that I promised on oath to their
ancestors, to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob: 'I will give your descendants
a land flowing with milk and honey.' 8 They will eat and be full, and
then turn to foreign gods, which cannot rescue them from any of
their troubles; and this witness will be heard against them. 9 They will
forget every commandment I give them, and follow the nations, their
filth and their shamelessness, and serve their gods, and those gods
will become a trap, a distress, an affliction, and a snare for them. 10

Many will be destroyed and carried off, and will fall into the hands of their enemies, because they abandoned my rules and my commandments, the festivals of my covenant, my sabbaths, my holy place that I made holy for myself among them, my tabernacle, and my sanctuary, which I made holy for myself in the middle of the land, so that I might set my name there and have it dwell.[d] 11 They will build themselves high places, sacred poles, and carved idols, and each will bow down to his own, and be led astray; they will sacrifice their children to demons and to every product of their hearts' delusion. 12 I will send witnesses to them to testify against them, but they will not listen; they will kill the witnesses, and hunt down those who look for the law. They will do away with it all and twist it into something wicked in my sight. 13 Then I will hide my face from them and hand them over to the nations to be taken captive, plundered, and devoured. I will uproot them from the land and scatter them among the nations. 14 They will forget my whole law, all my commandments, and all my judgments, and lose their way over the new moons, sabbaths, festivals, jubilees, and ordinances.[e] 15 After that they will turn back to me from among the nations, with all their heart, all their soul, and all their strength. I will gather them from all the nations, and they will look for me, and I will let them find me when they look for me with all their heart and all their soul. 16 I will show them plentiful peace with justice, and I will plant them as a plant of uprightness, with all my heart and all my soul.[f] They will be a blessing and not a curse; they will be the head and not the tail. 17 I will build my sanctuary among them and live with them; I will be their God, and they will be my people in truth and righteousness. 18 I will not abandon them or let them down, for I am the Lord their God." 19 Moses fell on his face and prayed: "Lord, my God, do not abandon your people and your inheritance, to wander in the delusions of their own hearts. Do not hand them over to their enemies, the nations, to rule over them and make them sin against you. 20 Lord, lift up your mercy over your people, and create in them an upright spirit. Do not let the spirit of Beliar rule them, accuse them before you, and trap them off every path of righteousness, so that they are destroyed from your presence.[g] 21 They are your people and

your inheritance, whom you rescued with your great power from the Egyptians. Create in them a clean heart and a holy spirit, and never let them be trapped by their sins, from now on and forever." 22 The Lord answered Moses: "I know how perverse they are, with their schemes and their stubbornness. They will not obey until they confess their own sin and the sin of their ancestors. 23 After that they will turn back to me in complete uprightness, with their whole heart and soul. I will cut away the foreskin of their hearts and of the hearts of their descendants, and create a holy spirit in them, and cleanse them so that they never again turn away from me, from that day on and forever. 24 Their souls will cling to me and to all my commandments, and they will keep them; I will be their Father, and they will be my children. 25 All of them will be called children of the living God, and every angel and every spirit will know that these are my children, that I am their Father in truth and justice, and that I love them. 26 Now write down for yourself all these words that I tell you on this mountain, the first and the last, everything that will happen in all the divisions of days, under the law and the testimony, in the weeks and the jubilees, forever, until I come down and live with them for all time." 27 Then he said to the angel of the presence, "Write for Moses from the beginning of creation until my sanctuary is built among them for all eternity.[h] 28 The Lord will appear before the eyes of all, and all will know that I am the God of Israel, the Father of all Jacob's children, and king on Mount Zion forever. Zion and Jerusalem will be holy."[i] 29 Then the angel of the presence, who went ahead of Israel's camp, took the tablets of the divisions of the years, from the time of creation, the law and the testimony of the weeks and the jubilees, year by year, in the full count of the jubilees, from the day of the new creation, when the heavens, the earth and all creation will be renewed according to the powers of heaven and all the works of the earth, until the Lord's sanctuary is made in Jerusalem on Mount Zion, and all the lights are renewed for healing, peace, and blessing for all the chosen of Israel, so that it may be so from that day forever.[j]

Notes

- a (1:1) The sixteenth day of the third month: Geʿez gives only "the third month, the sixteenth day." Jubilees counts months by number (as the older books of the Bible often do) in its fixed 364-day calendar, which begins at the spring equinox on a Wednesday (see the note at 6:29–32). In that calendar the sixteenth day of the third month falls in early June, a day after the Feast of Weeks that Jubilees fixes on the fifteenth (6:17–22). Compare Exod 19:1.
- b (1:1) The Prologue, which Charles prints before 1:1 without a verse number, reads: "This is the account of the division of the days, of the law and the testimony, of the events of the years, of their weeks of years and their jubilees, through all the years of the world, as the Lord told Moses on Mount Sinai when he went up to receive the tablets of the law and the commandment, at God's own word to him: 'Go up to the top of the mountain.'" A week of years is seven years; a jubilee is seven such weeks, forty-nine years (compare Lev 25).
- c (1:4) The earlier and the later history: the Ethiopic has "the first and the last," which Charles takes to mean the whole sweep of history, from creation to the final age. The book presents itself as that revelation, dictated to Moses by an angel (1:27).
- d (1:10) My holy place … my sanctuary: the Temple in Jerusalem. The writer speaks of the tabernacle as still standing in the time of the kings, and the "land" that holds the sanctuary is Judah.
- e (1:14) Lose their way over the new moons: an early hint of the book's main quarrel. Jubilees insists that the year has exactly 364 days, 52 weeks, with festivals on fixed dates, and rejects calendars governed by the moon (see 6:29–38).
- f (1:16) I will plant them as a plant of uprightness: the Ethiopic text is damaged here (Charles marks it as corrupt). The sense given is his proposed restoration, "I will plant them … in the land," following Jer 32:41.
- g (1:20) Beliar: the Ethiopic form of Belial ("worthlessness"), here the chief of the evil spirits. He appears again in 1:20 and in Jubilees' other mentions of demonic rule; compare Mastema (10:8).
- h (1:27) The angel of the presence: the angel who stands before God's face (Isa 63:9). Later (2:1) he dictates the account to Moses, and Jubilees is presented as his words. Charles suggested Michael. The idea that the law came through angels is also found in Gal 3:19.
- i (1:28) This verse stands here in the manuscripts, but Charles thought it belongs after verse 25.
- j (1:29) Charles considered the middle of this sentence damaged in the Ethiopic. The "new creation" looks ahead to the end of days (compare Isa 65:17; Rev 21:1).

Chapter 2

The Creation and the Sabbath

[1] The angel of the presence spoke to Moses at the Lord's word: "Write the full story of creation: how the Lord God finished all his work and

everything he made in six days, rested on the seventh day, made it holy for all ages, and set it as a sign for all his works. 2 On the first day he made the heavens above, the earth, the waters, and all the spirits that serve before him: the angels of the presence, the angels of holiness, the angels of the spirits of fire, of the winds, of the clouds, of darkness, of snow, hail and frost, the angels of the voices, of thunder and lightning, the angels of the spirits of cold and heat, winter and spring, autumn and summer, and of every spirit of his creatures in heaven and on earth. He also made the depths and the darkness, evening and night, and the light, dawn and day, which he prepared in the knowledge of his heart.[a] 3 Then we saw his works and praised him and sang before him for all that he had made, for he made seven great works on the first day. 4 On the second day he made the firmament in the midst of the waters, and the waters were divided that day: half rose above it and half sank below it, over the surface of the whole earth. This was the only work he made on the second day. 5 On the third day he commanded the waters to withdraw from the surface of the whole earth into one place, and the dry ground to appear. 6 The waters obeyed him, pulling back from the face of the earth into one place beyond this firmament, and the dry ground appeared. 7 That day he made for them all the seas, each in its basin, all the rivers, the pools of water in the hills and across the earth, all the lakes, all the dew on the ground, and the seed that is sown, all that sprouts, the fruit trees, the trees of the forest, and the garden of Eden in Eden, and every plant of every kind. These four great works God made on the third day.[b] 8 On the fourth day he made the sun, the moon, and the stars, and set them in the sky's firmament to give light over the whole earth, to rule the day and the night, and to separate light from darkness. 9 God set the sun as a great sign on the earth, for days, sabbaths, months, festivals, years, sabbaths of years, jubilees, and every season of the years.[c] 10 It separates light from darkness and brings prosperity, so that everything that grows and sprouts on the earth may thrive. These three things he made on the fourth day. 11 On the fifth day he made the great sea creatures in the depths of the waters; these were the first flesh made by his hands. He made the fish and everything

that moves in the water, and everything that flies, the birds and all their kinds. 12 The sun rose over them to make them thrive, and over everything on the earth, everything that sprouts from the ground, all the fruit trees, and all flesh. These three kinds he made on the fifth day. 13 On the sixth day he made all the wild animals of the earth, all the livestock, and everything that moves on the ground. 14 After all that, he made humankind, male and female, and gave them rule over everything on the earth and in the seas, over everything that flies, over the wild animals, the livestock, and everything that moves on the ground, over the whole earth; over all of this he gave them rule. These four kinds he made on the sixth day. 15 In all there were twenty-two kinds of things.[d] 16 He finished all his work on the sixth day: everything in the heavens and on the earth, in the seas and in the depths, in light and in darkness, and in everything. 17 He gave us a great sign, the sabbath day, so that we would work six days and keep sabbath on the seventh from all work. 18 All the angels of the presence and all the angels of holiness, these two great orders, he commanded to keep sabbath with him in heaven and on earth. 19 He said to us, 'I will set apart a people for myself from all the peoples, and they will keep the sabbath. I will make them holy as my own people and bless them. Just as I have made the sabbath day holy, and still do, so I will bless them, and they will be my people and I will be their God. 20 I have chosen the descendants of Jacob out of everything I have seen and I have written him down as my firstborn son. I have made him holy for myself forever, and I will teach them the sabbath day, so that they may rest on it from all work.' 21 So he made in it a sign, so that they would keep sabbath with us on the seventh day, to eat and drink and bless the one who made all things, who has blessed and made holy for himself a special people above all peoples, and so that they would keep sabbath along with us. 22 He made their commands rise to him like a sweet fragrance, welcome to him every day. 23 There were twenty-two heads of the human race from Adam to Jacob, and twenty-two kinds of work were done until the seventh day. This seventh day is blessed and holy, and the other one is blessed and holy too; the one serves with the other for holiness and blessing.[e] 24 It was

granted that Jacob and his descendants should always be the blessed and holy ones of the first testimony and law, just as he made the sabbath day holy and blessed on the seventh day. [25] He made heaven and earth and all that he made in six days, and God made the seventh day holy, because of all his works. So he commanded that anyone who does any work on it must die, and anyone who profanes it must surely die.[f] [26] So command the Israelites to keep this day and make it holy, to do no work on it and not to defile it, for it is holier than all other days. [27] Anyone who profanes it must certainly die, and anyone who does any work on it will die forever, so that the Israelites keep this day through all their generations and are not rooted out of the land. It is a holy day and a blessed day. [28] Everyone who keeps it, and rests on it from all his work, will be holy and blessed always, like us. [29] Tell the Israelites the law of this day: that they should keep sabbath on it and not abandon it in the delusions of their hearts; that it is not allowed to do on it anything inappropriate or to pursue their own pleasure; that they should not prepare anything to eat or drink on it, nor draw water, nor carry any load in or out through their gates that they did not prepare for themselves at home on the sixth day.[g] [30] They must not bring anything in or out from house to house on that day, for that day is holier and more blessed than any jubilee day in the jubilees. On it we kept sabbath in heaven before it was made known to any human being that they should keep sabbath on the earth. [31] The Creator of all things blessed it, but he did not make all peoples and nations holy to keep the sabbath on it; only Israel. Only to them did he grant eating, drinking, and keeping sabbath on the earth. [32] The Creator of all things blessed this day that he had made, for a blessing, for holiness, and for glory above all days. [33] This law and testimony was given to the Israelites as an everlasting law throughout their generations.

Notes

- a (2:2) Seven works on the first day: heaven, earth, waters, spirits, the abysses, darkness, and light (verse 3 speaks of seven). The angels, in this book, are made on the first day, so they could not have helped with later work; later Jewish tradition disputed this. The two highest orders are “angels of the presence” and “angels of

holiness." The rest are the angels who govern natural forces; compare 1 Enoch 60:11–21 and 75:3.

- b (2:7) Four works on the third day: Genesis names three (dry land and seas, plants, fruit trees); Jubilees adds the garden of Eden.
- c (2:9) The sun, and not the moon, is the sign. This is the book's central calendar claim: it follows the sun's fixed year of 364 days (52 weeks), and the moon plays no part in its reckoning (compare 6:36–38).
- d (2:15) Twenty-two: seven on day one, one on day two, four on day three, three on day four, three on day five, four on day six. The number matches the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, the twenty-two books (of the Hebrew Bible, as counted), and the twenty-two generations from Adam to Jacob (verse 23).
- e (2:23) Between verses 22 and 23 Charles marks a gap in the Ethiopic and proposes this restoration: "As there are twenty-two letters, and twenty-two sacred books, and twenty-two heads of humankind from Adam to Jacob, so there were twenty-two kinds of work." "The other one" in the second half of this verse is Jacob (Israel).
- f (2:25) Compare Exod 31:14–15 and Num 15:32–36.
- g (2:29) Charles considered part of this verse out of order in the Ethiopic. The ban on carrying burdens recalls Jer 17:21–22. Anything to eat was to be prepared the day before (Exod 16:23).

Chapter 3

Eden and the Fall

1 During the six days of the second week, at God's word, we brought to Adam all the wild animals, livestock, birds, and everything that moves on the ground or in the water, each by kind and species: the wild animals on the first day, the livestock on the second, the birds on the third, everything that moves on the ground on the fourth, and what moves in the water on the fifth.[a] 2 Adam gave names to them all, and whatever he called each one became its name. 3 For those five days Adam watched all of them, male and female, of every kind on earth, but he was alone, and found no companion suitable for him. 4 Then the Lord said to us, "It is not good for the man to be alone. Let us make a helper for him." 5 The Lord our God sent a deep sleep upon him, and he slept. God took one of his ribs to make the woman; this rib was the beginning of the woman. He built up flesh in its place and formed the woman. 6 Then he roused Adam from his sleep, and as soon as Adam woke he rose to his feet; it was the sixth day. The Lord led the woman to him, and Adam recognized her and said, "At

last: bone from my bones, flesh from my flesh! She shall be called my wife, since she was drawn out of her husband." [7] For this reason a man and his wife become one: a man leaves his father and mother, attaches himself to his wife, and the two become a single body. [8] Adam was made in the first week, and the rib, his wife, in the same week; in the second week God showed her to him. For this reason the commandment was given to keep the days of uncleanness: seven days for a male child, and twice seven for a female.[b] [9] When Adam had completed forty days in the land where he was made, we brought him into the garden of Eden to work it and take care of it, but his wife was brought in on the eightieth day, and only after that did she enter the garden of Eden. [10] This is why the commandment about a woman giving birth is written on the heavenly tablets: "If she gives birth to a boy, she is unclean for seven days, as in the first week of days, and then thirty-three days she must remain in the blood of her purifying. She must touch nothing holy and must not enter the sanctuary until she has completed the days set for a male child.[c] [11] But for a girl she is unclean for two weeks of days, as in the first two weeks, and sixty-six days in the blood of purifying, eighty days in all." [12] When she had completed eighty days, we brought her into the garden of Eden, because it is holier than all the rest of the earth, and every tree planted in it is holy. [13] So the rule for a woman who bears a boy or a girl is these days: she must touch nothing holy and not enter the sanctuary until those days for a boy or a girl are complete. [14] This is the law and testimony written for Israel, so that they will keep it always. [15] In the first week of the first jubilee, Adam and his wife lived in the garden of Eden for seven years, working and tending it; we gave him tasks and taught him everything fit for farming.[d] [16] He worked the garden, and was naked and did not know it, and was not ashamed. He guarded the garden from the birds, wild animals, and livestock, gathered its fruit and ate it, and put aside the rest for himself and his wife. [17] When the seven years were complete, in the second month, on the seventeenth day, the serpent came to the woman and said, "Did God tell you not to eat from every tree in the garden?" [18] She answered, "God told us we may eat the fruit of all the trees of the garden, but about the fruit

of the tree in the middle of the garden, God said, ‘Do not eat it, and do not even touch it, or you will die.’” 19 The serpent said to the woman, “You certainly will not die. God knows that on the day you eat it, your eyes will be opened, you will be like gods, and you will know good and evil.” 20 The woman saw that the tree was pleasant and lovely to look at, and that its fruit was good to eat, and she took some and ate. 21 She first covered her shame with fig leaves, then gave some to Adam, and he ate; his eyes were opened, and he saw that he was naked. 22 He took fig leaves and sewed them together, made himself an apron, and covered his shame. 23 God cursed the serpent and was angry with it forever.[e] 24 He was angry with the woman, because she had listened to the serpent’s voice and eaten. He said to her, “I will greatly increase your sorrow and pain; you will bear children in sorrow, and you will turn back to your husband, and he will rule over you.”[f] 25 To Adam he said, “Because you listened to your wife and ate from the tree I told you not to eat from, the ground is cursed because of you. It will produce thorns and thistles for you, and you will eat your bread by the sweat of your face, until you return to the earth you were taken from; you are earth, and to earth you will return.” 26 He made them coats of skin, dressed them, and sent them out of the garden of Eden. 27 On the day Adam left the garden, he offered a sweet-smelling offering of incense—frankincense, galbanum, stacte, and spices—in the morning when the sun rose, the day he had covered his shame.[g] 28 That day the mouths of all the wild animals, livestock, birds, and every creature that walks or moves were shut, so that they could no longer speak; until then they had all spoken to one another with one lip and one tongue.[h] 29 He sent out of the garden of Eden every creature that had been in it, and all were scattered by kind and species to the places made for them. 30 To Adam alone he gave the means to cover his shame, out of all the animals and livestock. 31 That is why the heavenly tablets prescribe that all who know the judgment of the law must cover their shame and not uncover themselves as the nations do.[i] 32 On the new moon of the fourth month Adam and his wife left the garden of Eden and settled in the land of Elda, the land of their creation.[j] 33 Adam named his wife Eve. 34 They had no son until

the first jubilee, and after that he knew her.[k] 35 Adam worked the land as he had been taught in the garden of Eden.

Notes

- a (3:1) The "second week" is the second week of creation, counted from the first sabbath, which is the beginning of the first week of the world's history. The "we" is the angels of the presence, who speak throughout this account.
- b (3:8) Compare Lev 12:2–5. The writer explains the law of purification after childbirth from the order of events in Eden.
- c (3:10) The heavenly tablets: tablets in heaven on which God has written law and the course of history. Jubilees often appeals to them for rules, including some not found in the Pentateuch (1 Enoch 81:1–2 and 93:2 also mention them).
- d (3:15) Seven years: the first week of years. A tradition recorded in Jewish literature says that Adam was in Eden only a few hours; Jubilees makes it seven years.
- e (3:23) Charles suspected something has dropped out here. He suggested it described the loss of the serpent's legs, a tradition found in the Aramaic Targum on Genesis and in Josephus.
- f (3:24) You will turn back to your husband: so the Greek and Syriac in Gen 3:16; the Hebrew has "your desire will be for your husband."
- g (3:27) Compare the incense of Exod 30:34. Adam is made the first priest.
- h (3:28) Josephus also says that all creatures spoke in the garden. In Jubilees the single original language is Hebrew (12:25–26).
- i (3:31) The nations … uncover themselves: likely a reference to Greek athletic exercise in the nude, which pious Jews of the second century BC opposed (1 Macc 1:14–15; 2 Macc 4:12–14).
- j (3:32) The new moon of the fourth month: here "new moon" means the first day of the fourth month (about June 21, the summer solstice, in the 364-day calendar of Jubilees). Elda: perhaps a form of the Hebrew word for "birth." Charles thought so.
- k (3:34) Eve: Hebrew Ḥawwah, associated with "living" in Gen 3:20.

Chapter 4

Cain and Abel; the Line to Noah

1 In the third week of the second jubilee Eve gave birth to Cain, in the fourth week to Abel, and in the fifth week to her daughter Awan.[a] 2 In the first year of the third jubilee, Cain killed Abel, because God accepted Abel's sacrifice and refused Cain's offering. 3 He killed him in the field, and his blood cried out from the ground to heaven, accusing him of the murder. 4 The Lord rebuked Cain for killing Abel, made him a wanderer on the earth because of his brother's blood, and cursed him on the earth. 5 For that reason it is written on the heavenly tablets:

“Cursed is the one who strikes his neighbor in secret. Let everyone who has seen and heard say, ‘So be it.’ And cursed too is the one who saw and did not report it.”[b] 6 That is why, when we appear before the Lord our God, we report all the sin that is committed in heaven and on earth, in light and in darkness, and everywhere. 7 Adam and his wife grieved over Abel for four weeks of years. In the fourth year of the fifth week they were glad again, and Adam knew his wife, and she bore a son. He named him Seth, saying, “God has raised up a second child for us on the earth in place of Abel, because Cain killed him.”[c] 8 In the sixth week he fathered his daughter Azura. 9 Cain took his sister Awan as his wife, and at the end of the fourth jubilee she bore him Enoch. In the first year of the first week of the fifth jubilee, houses were built on the earth, and Cain built a city and named it after his son Enoch.[d] 10 Adam knew Eve his wife, and she bore nine more sons. 11 In the fifth week of the fifth jubilee Seth took his sister Azura as his wife, and in the fourth year of the sixth week she bore him Enos. 12 He was the first to call on the name of the Lord on the earth. 13 In the third week of the seventh jubilee Enos took his sister Noam as his wife, and in the third year of the fifth week she bore him a son, whom he named Kenan. 14 At the end of the eighth jubilee Kenan took his sister Mualeleth as his wife, and in the first week of the ninth jubilee, in the third year, she bore him a son, whom he named Mahalalel.[e] 15 In the second week of the tenth jubilee Mahalalel took Dinah, daughter of Barakiel, his father’s brother’s daughter, as his wife, and in the third week, in the sixth year, she bore him a son, whom he named Jared, because in his days the angels of the Lord came down to earth.[f] They are called the Watchers, and were sent to teach people, and to practice justice and uprightness on earth. 16 In the eleventh jubilee, during its fourth week, Jared married Baraka, the daughter of Rasuel, who was his cousin on his father’s side. In the fifth week, in the jubilee’s fourth year, she bore him a son, whom he called Enoch. 17 Enoch was the first person born on earth to learn writing, knowledge, and wisdom, and he wrote the signs of the sky in a book, in the order of their months, so that people might know the seasons of the years in the order of their months.[g] 18 He was the first to write a testimony, and he testified to the

human race in the generations of the earth. He set out the weeks of the jubilees, made known the days of the years, arranged the months, and counted the sabbaths of years, as we had shown him. [19] He saw in a dream-vision what has been and what will be, how it will go for human beings in all their generations until the day of judgment. He saw and understood everything, wrote down his testimony, and placed it on earth for all human beings and their generations. [20] In the twelfth jubilee, in the seventh week, he took a wife named Edni, daughter of Danel, his father's brother's daughter, and in the sixth year of that week she bore him a son, whom he named Methuselah. [21] He then spent six jubilees of years with God's angels, who showed him everything on earth and in heaven, the course of the sun, and he wrote it all down. [22] He warned the Watchers who had sinned with the daughters of men; they had begun to join themselves to them and to be defiled, and Enoch bore witness against all of them. [23] He was taken from among human beings, and we led him into the garden of Eden in majesty and honor, and there he writes down the condemnation and judgment of the world and all the wickedness of humankind.[h] [24] Because of that, God brought the waters of the flood over all the land of Eden, for he was put there as a sign, to testify against all human beings and recount every deed of every generation until the day of judgment. [25] He burned the incense of the sanctuary, sweet-smelling spices, welcome to the Lord on the mountain. [26] For the Lord has four places on earth: the garden of Eden, the mountain of the east, this mountain where you are today, Mount Sinai, and Mount Zion, which will be made holy in the new creation to make the earth holy; through it the earth will be cleansed of all its guilt and uncleanness in all the generations of the world.[i] [27] In the fourteenth jubilee Methuselah took a wife, Edna, daughter of Azriel, his father's brother's daughter, in the third week, in the first year of that week, and he fathered a son and named him Lamech. [28] In the fifteenth jubilee, in the third week, Lamech took a wife named Betenos, daughter of Barakiel, his father's brother's daughter, and in that week she bore him a son. He named him Noah, saying, "This one will comfort me in my trouble and all my work, and over the ground that the Lord cursed."[j] [29] At the end of

the nineteenth jubilee, in the seventh week, in its sixth year, Adam died, and all his sons buried him in the land of his creation. He was the first to be buried in the earth. 30 He was seventy years short of a thousand years, for a thousand years are like one day in the testimony of heaven, and so it was written about the tree of knowledge: "On the day you eat from it you will die." For that reason he did not complete the years of that day; he died during it.[k] 31 At the end of that jubilee, in the same year, Cain was killed after him; his house fell on him, and he died in the middle of it, killed by its stones. He had killed Abel with a stone, and a stone killed him, a just judgment. 32 For that reason it was ordained on the heavenly tablets: "With the tool a man uses to kill his neighbor, he is to be killed; as he wounded him, so they are to treat him."[l] 33 In the twenty-fifth jubilee Noah took a wife named Emzara, daughter of Rakeel, his father's brother's daughter, in the first year of the fifth week. In the third year of it she bore him Shem, in the fifth year Ham, and in the first year of the sixth week Japheth.

Notes

- a (4:1) Jubilees fills in what Genesis leaves out, including the wives of the early patriarchs, who are all sisters or cousins. Awan: "iniquity" (Hebrew 'awen). Cain's wife is his sister in this book, as in later Jewish tradition.
- b (4:5) Compare Deut 27:24.
- c (4:7) Seth: in Gen 4:25 Eve explains the name as "God has appointed (shath) another child." In Jubilees the father usually names the child.
- d (4:9) Years in this book can be counted from creation: the first year of the first week of the fifth jubilee is year 197 (4 × 49 + 1). Charles gives these year numbers in his margins; they follow the book's own chronology, in which a jubilee is forty-nine years.
- e (4:14) Mualeleth: perhaps "she who praises God."
- f (4:15) Jared: the name suggests the Hebrew verb yarad, "come down." The angels who came down are the Watchers, described in 1 Enoch 6.
- g (4:17) Enoch writes the signs of the sky: compare the Astronomical Book (1 Enoch 72–82), which also lays out a 364-day solar year. Jubilees claims for the calendar the authority of the first scribe.
- h (4:23) Taken from among human beings: Gen 5:24. Here he is in Eden as a heavenly scribe, as in 1 Enoch 12:3–4.
- i (4:26) Four places: three of them are tied to a great figure—Eden to Adam, Sinai to Moses, Zion to David. The "mountain of the east" is uncertain; Charles allowed that it may be the mountain above Eden where Seth's family lived.

- j (4:28) Noah: Hebrew Noaḥ, tied to "comfort" (naḥam) in Gen 5:29.
- k (4:30) A thousand years are like one day: compare Ps 90:4 and 2 Pet 3:8. Adam lived 930 years (Gen 5:5); Jubilees says 930, "seventy short of a thousand."
- l (4:32) The law of equal retribution: compare Exod 21:24; Lev 24:19–20.

Chapter 5

The Watchers, the Giants, and the Flood

1 When human beings began to multiply across the earth and daughters were born to them, the angels of God saw them in a certain year of this jubilee, saw that they were beautiful, and took wives for themselves from any they chose. They bore sons to them, and these were giants.[a] 2 Lawlessness grew on the earth, and all flesh corrupted its way: human beings, livestock, wild animals, birds, and everything that walks on the earth all corrupted their ways and their natures. They began to devour one another, lawlessness grew on the earth, and every thought of every human heart was evil continually. 3 God looked at the earth, and it was corrupt: all flesh had corrupted its natural order, and everything on the earth had done every kind of evil before his eyes. 4 He said, "I will destroy people and all flesh on the face of the earth, which I made." 5 But Noah found favor in the Lord's eyes. 6 He was furious with the angels whom he had sent to earth, and commanded that they be uprooted from all their power. He told us to bind them in the depths of the earth, and there they are, bound in the midst of it, and kept apart. 7 Against their sons a command went out from before his face: that they be struck down with the sword and removed from under heaven. 8 He said, "My spirit will not remain in human beings forever, for they too are flesh, and their days will be a hundred and twenty years."[b] 9 He sent his sword among them so that each killed his neighbor, and they began to kill each other until all had fallen by the sword and been wiped from the earth. 10 Their fathers saw their destruction, and afterward were bound in the depths of the earth forever, until the day of the great condemnation, when judgment will be carried out on all who have corrupted their ways and works before the Lord.[c] 11 He destroyed all of them from their places, and not one remained whom he did not judge according to all their wickedness. 12 He made a new and righteous nature for all his

works, so that they would not sin in their whole nature forever, but all be righteous, each according to its kind, always. 13 The judgment of all is ordained and written on the heavenly tablets in justice, even the judgment of all who leave the path set for them to walk. If they do not walk in it, judgment is written for every creature and for every kind. 14 There is nothing in heaven or on earth, in light or in darkness, in Sheol or in the deep, or in the place of darkness, that is not judged; all their judgments are ordained, written, and engraved. 15 He will judge all of them, the great according to their greatness and the small according to their smallness, each according to his path. 16 He does not show partiality, nor does he accept bribes. If he says he will judge each one, then even if someone gave everything on earth, he would not accept the gifts or the person, and would take nothing from his hand, for he is a righteous judge. 17 The decree written down for the Israelites is this: if they come back to him in justice, he will forgive every offense and overlook every sin. 18 The decree is written that he will have compassion on all who repent of their guilt, one day in each year.[d] 19 As for all who corrupted their ways and thoughts before the flood, no one's person was accepted except Noah's; for his sake his sons were accepted, and God saved them from the waters of the flood on his account, because his heart was righteous in all his ways, as had been commanded concerning him, and he had not departed from anything ordained for him. 20 The Lord said he would destroy everything on the earth, people, livestock, wild animals, birds of the air, and everything that moves on the ground. 21 He commanded Noah to build an ark so that he could be saved from the waters of the flood. 22 Noah built the ark exactly as he was commanded, in the twenty-seventh jubilee of years, in the fifth week, in the fifth year, on the first day of the first month.[e] 23 In the sixth year of it, in the second month, on the first day of the second month, he entered, along with everything we brought to him, into the ark, and on the seventeenth, in the evening, the Lord shut it from outside.[f] 24 The Lord opened seven floodgates of heaven and the mouths of the springs of the great deep, seven mouths in number.[g] 25 The floodgates began to pour water from the sky for forty days and forty nights, and the springs of the deep

also sent up water, until the whole world was full of water. [26] The waters rose on the earth: fifteen cubits above all the high mountains.[h] The ark rose above the ground and moved across the surface of the waters. [27] The water covered the earth for five months, a hundred and fifty days. [28] The ark came to rest on the top of Lubar, one of the mountains of Ararat.[i] [29] When the fourth month began, the fountains of the great deep were sealed and the windows of heaven were shut. When the seventh month began, every opening in the earth's depths was uncovered, and the water started to sink away into the deep below. [30] On the first day of the tenth month the mountaintops were seen, and on the first day of the first month the earth was visible. [31] The waters disappeared from the earth in the fifth week, in its seventh year, and on the seventeenth day of the second month the earth was dry. [32] On the twenty-seventh day of it he opened the ark and sent out the wild animals, livestock, birds, and every moving thing.[j]

Notes

- a (5:1) Angels of God: the Hebrew of Gen 6:2 has "sons of God." Jubilees follows the older reading of the Greek version, "angels," and so does 1 Enoch (chapters 6–7). Giants: Hebrew Nephilim.
- b (5:8) Compare Gen 6:3.
- c (5:10) Charles argued that verses 10–12 describe the final judgment, so that "were bound" should be read "are bound" and the verbs in verse 11 are future: "He will destroy all from their places and not one will be left whom he does not judge." This translation keeps the Ethiopic tenses, which treat it as already happened.
- d (5:18) Verses 17–18 look like a later addition borrowed from 34:18–19. The reference is to the Day of Atonement, on the tenth day of the seventh month (about October 1 in the 364-day calendar; see 34:18–19).
- e (5:22) The twenty-seventh jubilee, fifth week, fifth year is year 1307 from creation (26 × 49 + 28 + 5). The first day of the first month is the first Wednesday of the year, in late March.
- f (5:23) On the first day of the second month: about April 21. The seventeenth of the second month: about May 7. The year in the 364-day calendar starts on a Wednesday at about the spring equinox. The seventeenth of the second month is Gen 7:11.
- g (5:24) Seven: in this book the number seven recurs in many places connected with the flood, as with the weeks and the jubilees.
- h (5:26) Fifteen cubits: about 22 feet (a cubit being about 18 inches, or 45 centimeters; about 6.7 meters). Compare Gen 7:20.
- i (5:28) Lubar: a mountain name found only in this book (see 7:1 and 7:17).

- j (5:32) Charles notes that Gen 8:14 gives the twenty-seventh day of the second month as the day the earth was dry; here the earth dries on the seventeenth and the ark is opened ten days later. The year of the flood, in all, runs from the second month (about April 21) through a year to the second month of the next year, a full 364-day year and ten days.

Chapter 6

Noah's Covenant, the Feast of Weeks, and the Year of 364 Days

1 On the first day of the third month he came out of the ark and built
an altar on that mountain.[a] 2 He made atonement for the earth, and
took a kid and made atonement with its blood for all the guilt of
the earth, for everything that had been on it was destroyed, except
those in the ark with Noah. 3 He put the fat of it on the altar. He took
an ox, a goat, a sheep, kids, salt, a turtledove, and a young pigeon,
and laid a burnt offering on the altar; he poured out on it a grain
offering mixed with oil, sprinkled wine, and strewed frankincense
over everything, and sent up a pleasing fragrance, welcome to the
Lord. 4 The Lord smelled the pleasing fragrance, and made a covenant
with him that there would never again be a flood to destroy the earth,
that seedtime and harvest would never cease in all the days of the
earth, and that cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night
would never change their order or end. 5 "As for you, be fruitful and
multiply on the earth, and become many on it, and be a blessing on
it. I will put fear and dread of you in everything that lives on the
earth and in the sea. 6 I have given you all the wild animals, all the
winged creatures, everything that moves on the ground, and the fish
in the waters, and everything, for food; as with the green plants, I
have given you everything to eat. 7 But you must not eat flesh with
its life, that is, with the blood. The life of all flesh is in the blood, or
else your own blood, your lives, will be demanded. From the hand
of every man and from the hand of every animal I will demand the
blood of a human being. 8 Whoever sheds a man's blood, by a man his
own blood will be shed, for God made humankind in his own image.
9 As for you, be fruitful and multiply on the earth." 10 Noah and his
sons swore that they would not eat any blood that was in any flesh,

and he made a covenant before the Lord God forever, throughout all the generations of the earth, in this month.[b] 11 For that reason he told you to make a covenant with the Israelites in this month, on the mountain, with an oath, and to sprinkle blood on them over all the words of the covenant that the Lord made with them forever.[c] 12 This testimony is written about you, that you must always keep it, and never eat the blood of any animal, bird, or livestock, on any day, in all the days of the earth. Anyone who eats the blood of an animal, livestock, or bird, in all the days of the earth, he and his descendants will be rooted out of the land. 13 Command the Israelites to eat no blood, so that their names and their descendants will always be before the Lord our God. 14 There is no limit of days for this law, for it is forever. They must keep it through their generations, so that they may keep making supplication for you with blood before the altar. Every day, morning and evening, they must seek forgiveness on your behalf continually before the Lord, so that they keep the covenant and are not rooted out.[d] 15 He gave Noah and his sons a sign that there would never again be a flood on the earth. 16 He set his bow in the cloud as a sign of the everlasting covenant, that there would never again be a flood to destroy the earth all the days of the earth. 17 For that reason it is ordained and written on the heavenly tablets that they celebrate the Feast of Weeks in this month, once a year, to renew the covenant every year.[e] 18 This whole festival was kept in heaven from the day of creation until the days of Noah: twenty-six jubilees and five weeks of years. Noah and his sons kept it for seven jubilees and one week of years, until the day Noah died. From that day his sons let it lapse until the days of Abraham, and they ate blood. 19 But Abraham kept it, and Isaac and Jacob and his children kept it, up to your time. In your time the Israelites forgot it, until you celebrated it again on this mountain. 20 Command the Israelites to keep this festival through all their generations as a commandment for them: on one day in the year, in this month, they are to celebrate the festival. 21 This is the Feast of Weeks, also called the Feast of First Fruits, a feast with two aspects and two purposes. Keep it as it is written and carved concerning it.[f] 22 For I wrote in the book of the first law, the one I wrote

for you, that you should celebrate it at its season, on one day in the year, and I explained its sacrifices to you, so that the Israelites would remember and celebrate it through their generations in this month, one day each year.[g] 23 On the first day of the first month, the first day of the fourth month, the first day of the seventh month, and the first day of the tenth month are days of remembrance and days of the seasons in the four divisions of the year. They are written and ordained as a testimony forever.[h] 24 Noah established them for himself as festivals for all generations forever, so that they became a memorial to him. 25 On the first day of the first month he was told to make the ark, and on that day the earth became dry and he opened it and saw the earth. 26 On the first of the fourth month the openings of the lower abysses were stopped up. On the first of the seventh month every vent in the earth's depths was uncovered, and the waters began pouring down into them. 27 On the first day of the tenth month the tops of the mountains were seen, and Noah was glad. 28 For that reason he established them for himself as festivals, as a lasting memorial, and so they are ordained. 29 They set them down on the heavenly tablets: each season has thirteen weeks, and from one memorial to the next passes thirteen weeks, from the first to the second, the second to the third, and the third to the fourth.[i] 30 All the days of the commandment are fifty-two weeks of days, and these make the whole year complete. 31 So it is engraved and ordained on the heavenly tablets, and there is no neglecting this commandment for a single year or from year to year. 32 Command the Israelites to keep the years by this count: three hundred and sixty-four days, and these make a complete year. They must not alter its time from its days or its festivals, for everything will fall out in them according to the testimony. They must not leave out a single day or disturb any festival.[j] 33 But if they neglect them and do not keep them as he commanded, they will disturb all their seasons, and the years will be shifted out of this order, and they will neglect their ordinances. 34 The Israelites will all forget. They will lose the track of the years, overlook the new moons, seasons, and sabbaths, and wander from the whole order of the year.[k] 35 For I know, and from now on I will tell you, and it is not of my own devising; the

book lies written before me, and the division of days is ordained on the heavenly tablets, so that they will not forget the festivals of the covenant and walk by the festivals of the nations, in their error and ignorance. 36 For there will be those who watch the moon carefully; it throws the seasons out of order, and each year it comes ten days early.[1] 37 A time will come when they overturn the order, treating a detestable day as the day of witness and an impure day as a feast. They will mix up all the days, holy ones with impure and impure with holy, and make errors about months, sabbaths, festivals, and jubilees. 38 For that reason I am commanding you and testifying to you, so that you may testify to them: after your death your descendants will disturb it, so that they will not make the year only three hundred and sixty-four days. For that reason they will go wrong about the beginnings of the months, the seasons, the sabbaths, and the festivals, and they will eat all kinds of blood with all kinds of flesh.

Notes

- a (6:1) That mountain: Lubar (5:28).
- b (6:10) In this month: the third month. The covenant with Noah, in this book, is renewed each year on the Feast of Weeks (verses 17–22).
- c (6:11) He told you: God is speaking to Moses through the angel. The sprinkling of blood is from Exod 24:8.
- d (6:14) This refers to the daily offering (Num 28:3–8). Charles noted that these verses carry the covenant with Noah over to Moses' time, and verse 15 returns to Noah.
- e (6:17) The Feast of Weeks (Hebrew Shavuot, later "Pentecost") comes fifty days after the offering of the first sheaf. In this book it is celebrated on the fifteenth day of the third month, and it is tied to Noah's covenant. Later Judaism associated it with the giving of the law on Sinai.
- f (6:21) A double nature: it commemorates the covenant with Noah and also marks the first fruits of the wheat harvest.
- g (6:22) The book of the first law is the Pentateuch, written by the angel. "One day" may also be read "the first day," meaning the first day of the week, Sunday; the Feast of Weeks then always falls on a Sunday in this calendar. This is also the view of the Sadducees.
- h (6:23) Days of remembrance: four days that begin the four quarters of the year (about March 22, June 21, September 20, and December 20). They correspond to the four "days that are not counted in the reckoning of the year" in 1 Enoch 75:1.
- i (6:29) This is the heart of the book's calendar. A year of 364 days is exactly 52 weeks, divided into four seasons of thirteen weeks (91 days: months of 30, 30, and

31 days). Because 364 is divisible by seven, each date falls on the same weekday every year. The year begins on a Wednesday, the fourth day of the week, when the sun and moon were made (2:8). Passover, the fourteenth of the first month, is always a Tuesday, the Feast of Weeks the fifteenth of the third month always a Sunday, and so on. The calendar is purely solar. It is also the calendar of 1 Enoch 72–82 and of many Dead Sea Scrolls, and it is one reason scholars link the book to the sect that kept the scrolls.

- j (6:32) Charles saw a difficulty: 52 weeks do not divide into twelve months of 30 days. The solution is in the four extra days that fall at the end of each quarter (months of 30, 30, and 31 days), the "days of remembrance" of verse 23.
- k (6:34) Compare 1 Enoch 82:4–6.
- l (6:36) Ten days early: a year of twelve lunar months has about 354 days, ten or eleven fewer than the 364-day year.

Chapter 7

Noah's Vineyard and His Warnings

1 In the seventh week, in its first year, in this jubilee, Noah planted vines on the mountain where the ark had come to rest, called Lubar, one of the Ararat mountains. They bore fruit in the fourth year, and he guarded the fruit and gathered it that year, in the seventh month.[a] 2 He made wine from it and put it in a jar and kept it until the fifth year, until the first day of the first month. 3 He celebrated the day of this feast with joy. He offered a burnt offering to the Lord: a young ox, a ram, seven sheep a year old, and a kid of the goats, to make atonement for himself and his sons.[b] 4 He prepared the kid first and put some of its blood on the flesh that was on the altar he had made, and he laid all the fat on the altar where he made the burnt offering, and the ox, the ram, and the sheep, with all their flesh. 5 He put all their grain offerings mixed with oil on it, and then sprinkled wine on the fire he had earlier lit on the altar, and he placed incense on the altar, and sent up a sweet fragrance, welcome to the Lord his God. 6 He rejoiced and drank some of this wine, he and his children, with joy. 7 In the evening he went into his tent, and being drunk he lay down and slept, and lay uncovered in his tent as he slept. 8 Ham saw his father Noah naked, and went out and told his two brothers outside. 9 Shem took a garment and got up, he and Japheth, and they put the garment on their shoulders and walked backward and covered their father's

nakedness, with their faces turned away. 10 Noah woke from his sleep
and knew all that his younger son had done to him, and he cursed
him and said, "Cursed be Canaan; he will be a slave to his brothers."[c] 11
He blessed Shem, saying, "Blessed be the Lord, the God of Shem, and
let Canaan be his slave. 12 May God enlarge Japheth, and may God live
in the tent of Shem, and may Canaan be his slave." 13 Ham knew that
his father had cursed his youngest son, and he was upset that he had
cursed his son, and he left his father, he and his sons with him: Cush,
Mizraim, Put, and Canaan. 14 He built himself a city and named it after
his wife, Neelatamauk. 15 Japheth saw it and was jealous of his brother,
and he too built himself a city and named it after his wife, Adataneses.
16 Shem lived with his father Noah, and built a city near his father,
on the mountain, and he too named it after his wife, Sedeqetelebab.[d]
17 These three cities lie near Mount Lubar: Sedeqetelebab facing the
mountain on the east, Neelatamauk on the south, and Adataneses on
the west. 18 These are the sons of Shem: Elam, Asshur, Arpachshad
(born two years after the flood), Lud, and Aram. 19 These are the sons
of Japheth: Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech, and Tiras.
These are the sons of Noah. 20 In the twenty-eighth jubilee Noah began
to teach his grandsons the ordinances and commandments, and all
the judgments he knew. He urged his sons to practice righteousness,
to cover the shame of their flesh, to bless their Creator, to honor
father and mother, to love their neighbor, and to guard their souls
from fornication, uncleanness, and all injustice.[e] 21 The flood came
on the earth because of these three things: the fornication in which
the Watchers, against the law of their ordinances, went chasing after
the daughters of men, taking wives from any they chose, and began
the uncleanness. 22 They fathered sons, the Naphidim, and these were
all unlike each other, and devoured each other. The giants killed the
Naphil, and the Naphil killed the Eljo, and the Eljo killed humankind,
and one person killed another.[f] 23 Everyone sold himself to do wrong
and shed much blood, and the earth was filled with injustice. 24 After
this they sinned against the animals and birds and everything that
moves or walks on the earth; much blood was shed on the earth,
and every thought and desire of human beings was vanity and evil

continually. 25 The Lord wiped out everything from the face of the
earth, because of the wickedness of their deeds, and because of the
blood they had shed in the midst of the earth. 26 “We were left, I and
you, my sons, and everything that entered the ark with us. Now I see
your works before me, and you are not walking in righteousness; you
have begun to walk the path of destruction, and you are splitting from
one another, jealous of one another, so that, my sons, you are not at
peace, each with his brother. 27 For I see that the demons have begun
to lead you and your children astray, and I fear for you that after my
death you will shed human blood on the earth, and that you too will
be wiped from the face of the earth. 28 Whoever sheds human blood
and whoever eats the blood of any flesh will all be wiped from the
earth. 29 No one will be left who eats blood or sheds human blood on
the earth, and no descendant of his will be left living under heaven.
They will go down to Sheol and into the place of condemnation, and
they will all be swept into the darkness of the deep by a violent death.
30 No blood is to be seen on you, from all the blood there will be all the
days that you kill any animal or livestock or anything that flies on
the earth. Do a good deed for your souls by covering what has been
shed on the surface of the earth. 31 Do not be like the person who eats
with the blood; guard yourselves so that no one eats blood in your
presence. Cover the blood, for so I have been commanded to testify
to you and your children, along with all flesh.[g] 32 Do not let the soul be
eaten with the flesh, so that your blood, which is your life, will not be
demanded from the hand of any flesh that sheds it on the earth. 33 The
land cannot be cleansed of blood that has been spilled on it, except by
the blood of the person who spilled it; only then will the land be made
pure for every generation. 34 Now, my children, listen: practice justice
and righteousness, so that you will be planted in righteousness across
the whole earth, and your glory be lifted high before my God, who
saved me from the waters of the flood. 35 You will go and build cities
for yourselves and plant in them all the plants on the earth, and all
the fruit trees as well. 36 For three years the fruit of anything that is
eaten will not be gathered. In the fourth year its fruit will be counted
as holy, and they will offer it, acceptable before the Most High God,

who made heaven and earth and everything. Let them offer the first of the wine and oil in abundance as first fruits on the altar of the Lord, who receives it, and let the servants of the Lord's house eat what is left before the altar that receives it.[h] 37 In the fifth year, make the release, so that you release it in justice and uprightness, and you will be righteous, and everything you plant will prosper.[i] 38 This is what Enoch, your father's father, commanded his son Methuselah, and Methuselah his son Lamech, and Lamech commanded me everything his fathers had commanded him. 39 I too will give you a command, my sons, as Enoch commanded his son in the first jubilees: while he was still alive, in the seventh generation, he commanded and testified to his son and his grandsons until the day of his death."

Notes

- a (7:1) Lubar: see the note at 5:28. Charles dates the planting at year 1317 from creation. A fruit tree's first three years of fruit were not to be eaten (Lev 19:23–25).
- b (7:3) The feast: the first day of the first month, the New Year in this calendar (about March 22). Compare Num 29:2.
- c (7:10) Compare Gen 9:25. In Jubilees the curse falls on Canaan because Noah's blessing had already been given to all three sons (Gen 9:1), and God had blessed Ham.
- d (7:16) The names of these wives come only from Jubilees. Sedeqetelebab appears to mean "righteousness of heart" (Hebrew ṣedeq + lebab).
- e (7:20) From here to the end of the chapter, Charles saw a piece of a lost "Book of Noah" (compare 10:1–15 and 1 Enoch 106:19–107:3). Later Jewish teaching ascribed seven commandments to the sons of Noah for all peoples.
- f (7:22) Naphidim, Naphil, Eljo: three classes of offspring. The Ethiopic spellings of the three names reflect Hebrew Nephilim and, perhaps, Elyo, a class otherwise unknown; Charles thought the text damaged here.
- g (7:31) Cover the blood: compare Lev 17:13. Jubilees traces the law of blood back to Noah, not Moses.
- h (7:36) Servants of the house of the Lord: the priests. Later Jewish law has the owners eat the rest in Jerusalem.
- i (7:37) The release: Charles read "in the seventh year let it rest." The Ethiopic text of the verse is uncertain.

Chapter 8

Kainam and the Division of the Earth

1 In the twenty-ninth jubilee, in the first week, at its beginning, Arpachshad took a wife named Rasuya, daughter of Susan, daughter

of Elam, and in the third year of that week she bore him a son, whom he named Kainam.[a] 2 The boy grew, and his father taught him to write, and he went off to look for a place where he could take a city for himself. 3 He found an inscription that people of earlier generations had carved on a rock, and read what was on it, and copied it. It led him into sin, for it held the teaching of the Watchers, by which they observed omens from the sun, moon, and stars, in all the signs of heaven.[b] 4 He wrote it down and said nothing about it, for he was afraid to speak to Noah about it, in case he be angry with him over it. 5 In the thirtieth jubilee, in the second week, in its first year, he took a wife named Melka, daughter of Madai, son of Japheth, and in the fourth year he fathered a son, whom he named Shelah, saying, "Truly I have been sent."[c] 6 Shelah grew up and took a wife named Muak, daughter of Kesed, his father's brother, in the thirty-first jubilee, in the fifth week, in its first year. 7 She bore him a son in its fifth year, and he named him Eber. Eber took a wife named Azurad, daughter of Nebrod, in the thirty-second jubilee, in the seventh week, in its third year. 8 In its sixth year she bore him a son, whom he named Peleg, because in the days when he was born Noah's descendants began to divide the earth among themselves; for that reason he named him Peleg.[d] 9 They divided it among themselves in secret, and told Noah. 10 At the beginning of the thirty-third jubilee they divided the earth into three parts, for Shem, Ham, and Japheth, each according to his inheritance, in the first year of the first week, when one of us, who had been sent, was with them. 11 He called his sons, and they came to him, they and their children, and he divided the earth into the lots that his three sons would take as their possession. They reached out their hands and took the writing from the bosom of Noah, their father. 12 On the writing, the lot of Shem came out as the middle of the earth, which he and his sons would take as an inheritance for themselves through the generations forever. It runs from the middle of the mountain range of Rafa, from the mouth of the water of the river Tina, and its portion goes west through the middle of this river and extends until it reaches the water of the abysses, out of which this river flows and pours its waters into the sea of Meat, and the river

flows into the great sea. Everything to the north is Japheth's, and everything to the south belongs to Shem.[e] 13 It extends until it reaches Karaso; this is in the bosom of the tongue that looks south. 14 His portion runs along the great sea, in a straight line until it reaches the west of the tongue that looks south, for this sea is called the tongue of the Egyptian sea. 15 From there it turns to the south, to the mouth of the great sea on the shore of its waters, and runs west to Afra, until it reaches the waters of the river Gihon, and south of the waters of Gihon, to the banks of this river.[f] 16 It runs east until it reaches the garden of Eden, to the south of it, and from the east of the whole land of Eden and the whole east it turns to the east, and goes on until it reaches the east of the mountain named Rafa, and comes down to the bank of the mouth of the river Tina. 17 This portion came to Shem and his sons by lot, to possess forever, through his generations, forever. 18 Noah was glad that this portion fell to Shem and his sons, and he remembered everything he had said in prophecy, for he had said, "Blessed be the Lord, the God of Shem, and may the Lord live in the dwelling of Shem." 19 He understood that Eden's garden is the holiest place and the Lord's dwelling, that Mount Sinai is the center of the wilderness, and that Mount Zion is the center, the navel, of the earth. These three were made as sacred places, each facing the others. 20 He blessed the God of gods, who had put the word of the Lord in his mouth, and he blessed the Lord forever. 21 He knew that a blessed portion and a blessing had come to Shem and his sons through all generations: the whole land of Eden, the whole land of the Red Sea, the whole land of the east, India, the Red Sea and its mountains, the whole land of Bashan, the whole land of Lebanon, the islands of Kaftur, all the mountains of Sanir and Amana, the mountains of Asshur in the north, all the land of Elam, Asshur, Babylon, Susa and Maidai, all the mountains of Ararat, and the whole region beyond the sea, beyond the mountains of Asshur in the north: a blessed and spacious land, and everything in it is very good.[g] 22 For Ham came out the second portion, beyond the Gihon toward the south, to the right of the garden, and it extends south to all the mountains of fire, and west to the sea of Atel, and west to the sea of Mauk, into which

everything that is not destroyed goes down.[h] 23 It goes north to the borders of Gadir and along the coast of the sea to the waters of the great sea, until it nears the river Gihon, and follows the river Gihon until it reaches the right of the garden of Eden.[i] 24 This is the land that came to Ham as his portion, to hold forever for himself and his sons through their generations forever. 25 Japheth's share was the third. It lay past the river Tina, north of where its waters empty out, and stretched northeast across all of Gog's territory and every land east of it. 26 It runs north, to the mountains of Qelt in the north, and toward the sea of Mauk, and comes out east of Gadir as far as the region of the waters of the sea.[j] 27 It runs until it approaches the west of Fara, and returns toward Aferag, and runs east to the waters of the sea of Meat. 28 It runs to the region of the river Tina in a northeasterly direction, until it nears the boundary of its waters, toward the mountain Rafa, and turns north. 29 This is the land that came to Japheth and his sons as the portion of his inheritance, to possess for himself and his sons through their generations forever: five great islands and a great land in the north. 30 Cold is its climate, while Ham's land is scorching; Shem's land is neither scorching nor cold but blends the two.

Notes

- a (8:1) Kainam (Cainan): he appears in the Greek version of Gen 11:13 and in Luke 3:36, but not in the Hebrew text.
- b (8:3) Josephus tells of knowledge of the stars carved on pillars by the sons of Seth. Here the knowledge is corrupt, since it comes from the Watchers. Compare 1 Enoch 8:3.
- c (8:5) Shelah: the name sounds like Hebrew shalaḥ, "send." Compare Gen 10:24.
- d (8:8) Peleg: Hebrew "division"; compare Gen 10:25.
- e (8:12) The geography of this chapter is that of a map: Rafa is probably the Rhipaean mountains (the Urals in ancient geography); Tina is the Tanais, the river Don; Meat is the Sea of Azov; Gihon is the Nile; the great sea is the Mediterranean. The scheme is of the Jewish map of the world, with Jerusalem as the "navel" of the earth (verse 19; compare Ezek 38:12 and 1 Enoch 26:1).
- f (8:15) Afra: the Roman province of Africa, the north African coast around Carthage.
- g (8:21) Kaftur: Caphtor, probably Crete. Sanir: Senir, the Hebrew name for Mount Hermon. Maidai: Media.
- h (8:22) The mountains of fire: the volcanic peaks of the south. The sea of Atel is the Atlantic; the sea of Mauk is the great ocean river that was supposed to encircle

the world. Charles suggested that the text may mean "into which everything that falls is destroyed."

- i (8:23) Gadir: Gades, modern Cádiz in Spain.
- j (8:26) Qelt: the Celts.

Chapter 9

The Portions of Noah's Grandsons

1 Ham divided his portion among his sons. The first portion came out
for Cush, to the east; west of him for Mizraim; west of him for Put;
and west of that, along the sea, for Canaan.[a] 2 Shem also divided his
portion among his sons. The first portion came out for Elam and his
sons, east of the Tigris, until it reaches the east: the whole land of
India, along the Red Sea on its coast, the waters of Dedan, all the
mountains of Mebri and Ela, the whole land of Susa, and everything
on the side of Pharnak, to the Red Sea and the river Tina. 3 For Asshur
came out the second portion: the whole land of Asshur, Nineveh, and
Shinar, as far as the border of India, and it climbs and skirts the river.
4 For Arpachshad came out the third portion: the whole land of the
Chaldean region east of the Euphrates, bordering the Red Sea, and all
the waters of the desert near the tongue of the sea that looks toward
Egypt, all the land of Lebanon, Sanir, and Amana, to the border of
the Euphrates. 5 For Aram came out the fourth portion: the whole
land of Mesopotamia between the Tigris and the Euphrates, north
of the Chaldeans, to the border of the mountains of Asshur and the
land of Arara. 6 For Lud came out the fifth portion: the mountains
of Asshur and everything belonging to them, until it reaches the
Great Sea, and the east of Asshur, his brother. 7 Japheth also divided
his inherited land among his sons. 8 The first portion came out for
Gomer, east of the northern side as far as the river Tina; in the north,
for Magog, came out all the inner parts of the north, until it reaches
the sea of Meat. 9 For Madai came out, as his portion to possess,
the land west of his two brothers, to the islands and to the coasts
of the islands. 10 For Javan came out the fourth portion: every island
and the islands toward the border of Lud.[b] 11 For Tubal came out the
fifth portion, in the middle of the tongue of land that approaches the
border of Lud's portion, to the second tongue, to the region beyond

the second tongue, up to the third tongue.[c] 12 For Meshech came out the sixth portion: the whole region beyond the third tongue, until it approaches the east of Gadir. 13 For Tiras came out the seventh portion: four great islands in the middle of the sea, which reach to Ham's portion; and the islands of Kamaturi fell by lot to the sons of Arpachshad as his inheritance.[d] 14 So Noah's sons divided it among their sons in the presence of Noah their father, and he bound them all with an oath, laying a curse on anyone who tried to seize a portion that had not fallen to him by lot. 15 They all said, "So be it, so be it," for themselves and their sons forever, through their generations until the day of judgment, when the Lord God will judge them with sword and fire for all the unclean wickedness of their errors, with which they have filled the earth with transgression, uncleanness, fornication, and sin.

Notes

- a (9:1) Cush: Ethiopia. Mizraim: Egypt. Put: Libya.
- b (9:10) Javan: Greece (Ionia).
- c (9:11) The three tongues are probably the three great peninsulas of southern Europe: Thrace, Greece, and Italy.
- d (9:13) The last clause looks like a later addition (Charles), since Arpachshad was a son of Shem.

Chapter 10

Demons, the Death of Noah, and the Tower of Babel

1 In the third week of this jubilee, unclean demons began to lead astray Noah's grandsons, and to make them go wrong and destroy them.[a] 2 Noah's sons came to their father Noah and told him about the demons that were leading astray, blinding, and killing his grandsons. 3 He prayed before the Lord his God: "God of the spirits of all humanity, you have been merciful to me. You rescued me and my sons from the floodwaters and did not wipe me out as you did those headed for destruction. Your favor to me has been immense, and your compassion for my soul has been immense. Let your favor rest on my sons, and do not let wicked spirits govern them, or they will wipe them from the earth. 4 But bless me and my sons, so that we may multiply and fill the earth. 5 You know how your Watchers, the fathers

of these spirits, acted in my day; and as for these spirits that are alive, lock them up and hold them fast in the place of condemnation, so that they do not bring destruction on the sons of your servant, my God; for these are malicious and were made to destroy. 6 Do not let them rule over the spirits of the living, for you alone can rule over them. Do not let them have power over the sons of the righteous from now on and forever." 7 The Lord our God told us to bind them all. 8 Mastema, the chief of the spirits, came and said, "Lord, Creator, let some of them stay with me, to listen to my voice and do all that I tell them; for if some are not left to me, I will not be able to carry out my will against human beings. They are meant for corruption and for leading astray under my judgment, for the wickedness of humankind is great."[b] 9 God said, "Let a tenth of them stay with him, and let nine parts go down into the place of condemnation."[c] 10 He told one of us to teach Noah all their medicines, for he knew they would not walk uprightly or strive in righteousness.[d] 11 We did everything he said: we bound all the malicious evil spirits in the place of condemnation, and left a tenth of them to be subject to Satan on the earth. 12 We explained to Noah all the medicines for their diseases and for their deceptions, and how he could heal with the herbs of the earth. 13 Noah wrote everything down in a book as we instructed him, about every kind of medicine. So the evil spirits were kept from hurting Noah's sons. 14 He gave all that he had written to Shem, his eldest son, for he loved him very much above all his sons. 15 Noah died and joined his ancestors, and was buried on Mount Lubar, in Ararat. 16 He completed nine hundred and fifty years of life: nineteen jubilees, two weeks of years, and five years.[e] 17 In his life on earth he surpassed all human beings except Enoch, because of his righteousness, in which he was perfect. Enoch's office was ordained as a testimony for the generations of the world, to recount all the deeds of each generation until the day of judgment. 18 In the thirty-third jubilee, in the first year of the second week, Peleg took a wife named Lomna, daughter of Sinar, and in the fourth year of this week she bore him a son and he named him Reu; for he said, "Look, human beings have become evil, with the wicked plan of building themselves a city and a tower in the land of Shinar."[f]

19 They left the land of Ararat and went east to Shinar, for in his days
they built the city and the tower, saying, “Come, let us climb up by
it into heaven.” 20 They began to build, and in the fourth week they
made bricks with fire, and the bricks served them as stone, and the
mortar they used to join them was asphalt, which comes out of the
sea and from springs of water in the land of Shinar. 21 They built it for
forty-three years. Its width was 203 bricks, and a brick was a third
of a unit in height; its height came to 5,433 cubits and 2 palms, and
one wall was thirteen stades long and the other thirty.[g] 22 The Lord
our God said to us, “Look, they are one people, and this is what they
have begun to do, and now nothing will be held back from them.
Come, let us go down and confuse their language, so that they will
not understand one another’s speech, and they will be scattered into
cities and nations, and a single purpose will never again be among
them until the day of judgment.” 23 The Lord came down, and we came
down with him to see the city and the tower that human beings had
built. 24 He confused their language, and they no longer understood
one another’s speech, and then they stopped building the city and
the tower. 25 For this reason the whole land of Shinar is called Babel,
because the Lord confused all the language of humankind there, and
from there they were scattered to their cities, each according to his
language and his nation. 26 The Lord sent a mighty wind against the
tower and threw it down to the earth. It lay between Asshur and
Babylon in the land of Shinar, and they called it “Overthrow.”[h] 27 In
the first year of the fourth week, at the beginning of the thirty-fourth
jubilee, they were scattered from the land of Shinar. 28 Ham and his
sons went into the land that he was to occupy, which he had acquired
as his portion in the land of the south.[i] 29 Canaan saw that the land of
Lebanon as far as the river of Egypt was very good, and he did not
go to the land of his inheritance in the west, by the sea, but settled in
the land of Lebanon, east and west, from the border of the Jordan and
from the border of the sea. 30 His father Ham and his brothers Cush
and Mizraim said to him, “You have settled in a land that is not yours,
and did not fall to us by lot. Do not do it; for if you do, you and your
sons will fall in the land and be cursed through rebellion; for you

have settled by rebellion, and by rebellion your children will fall, and you will be rooted out forever. 31 Do not live in the dwelling of Shem, for it came to Shem and his sons by their lot. 32 You are cursed, and you will be cursed beyond all Noah's sons, by the curse by which we bound ourselves with an oath before the holy judge and before Noah our father." 33 But he did not listen to them, and settled in the land of Lebanon from Hamath to the entrance of Egypt, he and his sons, to this day. 34 For this reason that land is called Canaan.[j] 35 Japheth and his sons went toward the sea and settled in the land of their portion. Madai saw the land by the sea and did not like it, and begged a portion from Elam, Asshur, and Arpachshad, his wife's brother, and settled in the land of Media, near his wife's brother, to this day. 36 He named his dwelling and the dwelling of his sons Media, after the name of their father Madai.

Notes

- a (10:1) Verses 1–15 are the other main piece of the "Book of Noah" (see ch. 7). The Hebrew original of verses 1–2 and 9–14 survives among the Dead Sea Scrolls, Charles noted. The "demons" are the spirits of the dead giants, the offspring of the Watchers and women (1 Enoch 15:8–12).
- b (10:8) Mastema means "hostility" or "animosity" (Hebrew mastemah; compare Hos 9:7–8). Here he is the chief of the evil spirits, and in 11:5 and 17:16 he is identified with Satan, the Adversary. In the Dead Sea Scrolls he is called Belial.
- c (10:9) Compare 1 Enoch 15–16, where all the demons are left free until the judgment.
- d (10:10) The angel was Raphael, whose name means "God heals" (Tobit 3:17; 12:14–15).
- e (10:16) 19 × 49 + 2 × 7 + 5 = 950 years. See Gen 9:29.
- f (10:18) Reu: sounds like Hebrew ra', "evil."
- g (10:21) The measurements of Jubilees, converted. A cubit is about 18 inches (45 cm), and a palm 3 inches (7.6 cm), so the 5,433 cubits and 2 palms is about 8,150 feet (2,484 m), a little more than a mile and a half. A stade is about 607 feet (185 m): thirteen stades is about 7,900 feet (2.4 km) and thirty stades about 18,200 feet (5.5 km). The numbers are legendary, and the text seems also confused.
- h (10:26) The tower's name in Jubilees is "Overthrow"; the real name was Babel (Hebrew bavel, a pun on balal, "confuse," in Gen 11:9). Jewish tradition says that seventy nations were created at Babel, each under an angel.
- i (10:28) "South" should read "north," as Charles saw: Ham's true portion was northwest Africa (8:22–24).

- j (10:34) Canaan: the ancient pun is lost, but the book plays on the name as "a land seized by Canaan."

Chapter 11

The Birth of Idolatry and the Family of Abram

1 In the thirty-fifth jubilee, in the first year of the third week, Reu took a wife named Ora, daughter of Ur, son of Kesed, and in the seventh year of this week, in this jubilee, she bore him a son and he named him Serug. 2 The sons of Noah began to fight one another, to take captives and kill one another, to shed human blood on the earth and eat blood, to build strong cities, walls, and towers; individuals began to raise themselves above the nation, to found the first kingdoms, and to go to war, people against people, nation against nation, and city against city. Everyone began to do evil, to acquire weapons, to teach their sons war, to capture cities, and to sell male and female slaves.[a] 3 Ur, son of Kesed, built the city of Ara of the Chaldeans, and named it after himself and his father.[b] 4 They made molten images for themselves, and each worshiped the idol, the molten image he had made. They began to make carved images and unclean likenesses, and malicious spirits helped and led them astray into transgression and uncleanness. 5 Prince Mastema worked hard to do all this, and sent out other spirits, those placed under his hand, to commit every sort of wrong and sin and transgression, to corrupt and destroy, and to shed blood on the earth. 6 For this reason he named Seroh "Serug," because everyone turned to commit every sort of sin and transgression.[c] 7 He grew up and lived in Ur of the Chaldeans, near his wife's mother's father, and worshiped idols. He took a wife in the thirty-sixth jubilee, in the first year of the fifth week, named Melka, daughter of Kabor, his father's brother's daughter. 8 In the first year of that week she bore him Nahor, and he grew up and lived in Ur of the Chaldeans, and his father taught him the studies of the Chaldeans, to practice divination and augury by the signs of heaven. 9 In the thirty-seventh jubilee, in the first year of the sixth week, he took a wife named Iyaska, daughter of Nestag of the Chaldeans. 10 In the seventh year of this week she bore him Terah. 11 Prince Mastema sent ravens and birds to devour the

seed that was sown in the land, to destroy the land and rob human beings of their labor. Before they could plow in the seed, the ravens picked it from the surface of the ground. 12 For this reason he named him Terah, because the ravens and the birds brought them to poverty and devoured their seed.[d] 13 The years began to be barren because of the birds, and they ate all the fruit from the trees; only with great effort could they save a little of all the fruit of the earth in their days. 14 In this thirty-ninth jubilee, in the first year of the second week, Terah took a wife named Edna, daughter of Abram, his father's sister. 15 In the seventh year of this week she bore him a son, and he named him Abram, after the name of his mother's father, for he had died before his daughter conceived. 16 The child began to understand the errors of the earth, that everyone had gone astray after carved images and uncleanness. His father taught him writing, and when he was two weeks of years old he separated himself from his father, so that he would not worship idols with him.[e] 17 He began to pray to the Creator of all things to save him from the errors of human beings, and that his portion would not fall into error after uncleanness and vileness. 18 The seedtime came for sowing seed on the land, and they all went out together to protect their seed from the ravens. Abram went with them, and the boy was fourteen years old. 19 A cloud of ravens came to eat the seed, and Abram ran to meet them before they landed on the ground, and cried to them before they landed to eat the seed, and said, "Do not come down; go back to where you came from," and they began to turn back. 20 That day he made the clouds of ravens turn back seventy times, and not one raven stayed anywhere in the land where Abram was. 21 Everyone in the country who was with him saw him shout and watched every raven turn away; his name grew great throughout Chaldea. 22 That year all who wanted to sow came to him, and he went with them until the time of sowing ended. They sowed their land, and that year they brought home enough grain, and ate and were satisfied. 23 In the first year of the fifth week, Abram taught the makers of tools for oxen, the woodworkers, and they made a container above the ground, facing the frame of the plow, to hold the seed, so that the seed fell down from it onto the plowshare and

was hidden in the earth, and they no longer feared the ravens.[f] 24 They made containers above the ground in the same way on all the plow frames, and they sowed and tilled all the land as Abram commanded them, and they no longer feared the birds.

Notes

- a (11:2) A note against monarchy: in this account the first kingdoms come from violence.
- b (11:3) "Ur of the Chaldeans" (Gen 11:28) is here read as two persons' names, Ur and Kesed.
- c (11:6) Serug is linked to Hebrew sarar, "turn aside, rebel."
- d (11:12) The Hebrew pun on Terah is uncertain.
- e (11:16) Two weeks of years: fourteen years old; Abram's age is given as in the fourteen-year-old of verse 18. The story of Abram's break with idolatry is the root of much later Jewish legend (compare the Apocalypse of Abraham).
- f (11:23) A seed drill: an improvement on scattering by hand. Rabbinic tradition ascribes the plow to Noah.

Chapter 12

Abram Burns the Idols and Leaves Ur

1 In the seventh year of the sixth week, Abram said to his father Terah, "Father!" He said, "Here I am, my son." 2 He said, "What help and profit do we get from these idols you worship, and bow down to? 3 There is no spirit in them. They are dumb forms, and a deception of the heart. Do not worship them. 4 Worship the God of heaven, who sends the rain and the dew on the earth, and does everything on the earth, and made everything by his word; all life is from before his face.[a] 5 Why do you worship things that have no spirit in them? They are the work of human hands, and you carry them on your shoulders, and you have no help from them; they are a great shame to those who make them, and a deception of the heart to those who worship them. Do not worship them." 6 His father said, "I know it too, my son, but what can I do with a people who have made me serve before them? 7 If I tell them the truth, they will kill me, for they are attached to them, to worship and honor them. Keep quiet, my son, or they will kill you." 8 He said these things to his two brothers, and they were angry with him, and he kept quiet. 9 In the seventh year of the second week of the fortieth jubilee, Abram took a wife named Sarai, the daughter of

his father, and she became his wife.[b] 10 Haran, his brother, took a wife
in the third year of the third week, and in the seventh year of this
week she bore him a son, and he named him Lot. 11 Nahor, his brother,
took a wife. 12 In the sixtieth year of Abram's life, in the fourth year
of the fourth week, Abram got up by night and burned the house of
the idols, and everything in it, and no one knew.[c] 13 They got up in
the night and tried to save their gods from the middle of the fire. 14
Haran hurried to save them, but the fire flared over him, and he was
burned in the fire and died in Ur of the Chaldeans before his father
Terah, and they buried him in Ur of the Chaldeans. 15 Terah left Ur
of the Chaldeans, he and his sons, to go to the land of Lebanon and
the land of Canaan, and he settled in the land of Haran, and Abram
lived with his father Terah in Haran for two weeks of years.[d] 16 In the
fifth year of the sixth week, Abram sat up all night on the first day
of the seventh month to watch the stars from evening to morning, to
see what the year would be like for rain, and he sat alone watching.[e]
17 A thought rose in his heart, and he said, "The signs of the stars, and
the paths of the sun and moon, all rest in the Lord's hand. Why am I
trying to investigate them? 18 If he wants, he sends rain, morning and
evening; if he wants, he holds it back. Everything is in his hand." 19 He
prayed that night and said, "My God, God Most High, you alone are
my God. I have chosen you and your dominion. You made everything,
and everything that exists is the work of your hands. 20 Rescue me
from the hands of the evil spirits who have power over the thoughts
of human hearts, and do not let them lead me astray from you, my
God. Establish me and my descendants forever, so that we do not go
astray from now on and forever." 21 He said, "Should I go back to Ur of
the Chaldeans, where they are seeking my face to have me return to
them, or am I to stay here in this place? Make the right path before
you prosper in the hands of your servant, so that he may do it and not
walk in the deceitfulness of my heart, my God." 22 He finished speaking
and praying, and the word of the Lord was sent to him through me,
saying, "Leave your country, your relatives, and your father's house
for a land I will show you, and I will make you a great and numerous
nation. 23 I will bless you and make your name great, and you will be

blessed on the earth, and in you all the families of the earth will be blessed. I will bless those who bless you, and curse those who curse you. 24 I will be a God to you and to your son, and to your son's son, and to all your descendants. Do not be afraid; from now on and for all generations of the earth I am your God." 25 The Lord God said, "Open his mouth and his ears, so that he can hear and speak with his mouth in the language that has been revealed," for it had stopped coming from the mouths of all human beings from the day of the overthrow of Babel.[f] 26 I opened his mouth, his ears, and his lips, and began to speak with him in Hebrew, the language of creation. 27 He took the books of his fathers, which were written in Hebrew, and copied them, and from then on began to study them, and I explained to him what he could not understand, and he studied them through the six rainy months.[g] 28 In the seventh year of the sixth week he spoke to his father and told him he was going to leave Haran to go to the land of Canaan, to see it and return to him. 29 His father Terah said to him, "Go in peace. May the eternal God make your path straight, and may the Lord be with you and protect you from all evil, and give you grace, mercy, and favor before those who see you, and may no human being have power over you to harm you. Go in peace. 30 If you see a land pleasant to your eyes to live in, then get up and take me to you, and take Lot with you, the son of Haran your brother, as your own son. The Lord be with you. 31 Leave your brother Nahor with me until you return in peace, and we will all go with you together."

Notes

- a (12:4) Abram's argument against idols closely follows Ps 115:4–8 and Jer 10:1–16. Its likeness to the Apocalypse of Abraham (chs. 1–8) shows both draw on one older legend.
- b (12:9) Sarai is Abram's half-sister (Gen 20:12). Later rabbis allowed such a marriage to Noah's descendants, but it is forbidden in Lev 18:9; 20:17.
- c (12:12) The sixtieth year of his life is the year of the world 1936 (nineteen centuries and thirty-six years after creation). Abram was born in 1876 (11:15).
- d (12:15) Fourteen years.
- e (12:16) The first day of the seventh month: about September 20 in the 364-day calendar, the beginning of the autumn rain season.

- f (12:25) The “language that has been revealed” is Hebrew, said here to be the original tongue of all humankind, lost at Babel and restored to Abram. See 12:26–27 and 3:28.
- g (12:27) The six rainy months: the winter half-year. Another tradition says that Eber alone kept Hebrew, because he took no part in building the tower.

Chapter 13

Abram in Canaan and Egypt

1 Abram left Haran, taking his wife Sarai and Lot, his brother Haran’s
son, to the land of Canaan; he came to Asshur and went on to
Shechem and settled near a tall oak.[a] 2 He saw that the land was very
pleasant, from the entrance of Hamath to the tall oak. 3 The Lord said
to him, “To you and your descendants I will give this land.” 4 He built
an altar there and offered a burnt offering on it to the Lord, who had
appeared to him. 5 He moved from there to the mountain between
Bethel on the west and Ai on the east, and pitched his tent there. 6 He
saw that the land was very wide and good, and everything grew on
it: vines, figs, pomegranates, oaks, holm oaks, terebinths, olive trees,
cedars, cypresses, date palms, and all the trees of the field, and there
was water on the mountains. 7 He blessed the Lord, who had led him
out of Ur of the Chaldeans and brought him to this land. 8 In the first
year of the seventh week, on the first day of the first month, he built
an altar on this mountain and called on the name of the Lord: “You,
the eternal God, are my God.”[b] 9 He offered a burnt offering on the
altar to the Lord, asking that he be with him and not leave him all the
days of his life. 10 He moved from there and went south, and came to
Hebron (Hebron was built at that time), and lived there for two years,
and went from there into the southern land, to Bealoth, and there
was a famine in the land.[c] 11 Abram went to Egypt in the third year of
the week, and lived in Egypt for five years before his wife was taken
from him. 12 Now Tanis in Egypt was built at that time, seven years
after Hebron.[d] 13 When Pharaoh took Sarai, Abram’s wife, the Lord
struck Pharaoh and his house with great plagues because of Sarai,
Abram’s wife. 14 Abram became very rich in flocks, cattle, donkeys,
horses, camels, male and female slaves, and in silver and gold in great
quantity. Lot, his brother’s son, was also wealthy. 15 Pharaoh returned

Sarai, Abram's wife, and sent Abram away from Egypt. He went back to the spot where he had first set up his tent, the site of the altar, with Ai to the east and Bethel to the west, and he blessed the Lord his God for bringing him back safe. [16] In the third year of the first week of the forty-first jubilee he returned to this place and offered a burnt offering on it, and called on the name of the Lord, and said, "You, the Most High God, are my God forever and ever." [17] In the fourth year of this week Lot parted from him, and Lot settled in Sodom, and the men of Sodom were very great sinners. [18] It grieved him in his heart that his brother's son had left him, for he had no children. [19] In that year when Lot was taken captive, in the fourth year of this week, the Lord said to Abram after Lot had separated from him, "Lift up your eyes from the place where you are staying, north and south, west and east. [20] All the land you see I will give to you and your descendants forever, and I will make your descendants as the sand of the sea. Though a man could count the dust of the earth, your descendants will not be counted. [21] Get up, walk through the land, its length and its breadth, and see it all, for I will give it to your descendants." Abram went to Hebron and lived there. [22] In this year Chedorlaomer, king of Elam, came with Amraphel, king of Shinar, Arioch, king of Sellasar, and Tergal, king of nations, and they killed the king of Gomorrah; the king of Sodom fled, and many fell wounded in the valley of Siddim by the Salt Sea.[e] [23] They took Sodom, Adam, and Zeboim captive, and they took Lot, the son of Abram's brother, captive, with all his possessions, and went to Dan.[f] [24] Someone who had escaped came and told Abram that his brother's son had been captured, and Abram armed his household servants. [25] . . . for Abram and his descendants, a tenth of the first fruits to the Lord, and the Lord ordained it as an ordinance forever, that they should give it to the priests who served before him, and that they should possess it forever.[g] [26] There is no limit of days to this law, for he ordained it for generations forever, that they should give the Lord the tenth of everything: of the seed, the wine, the oil, the cattle, and the sheep. [27] He gave it to his priests to eat and drink with joy before him. [28] The king of Sodom came to him and bowed before him, and said, "Our lord Abram, give us the people you have rescued, but

keep the plunder." [29] Abram said to him, "I lift up my hands to the Most High God: from a thread to a sandal strap I will not take anything of yours, so that you cannot say I made Abram rich; except only what the young men have eaten, and the share of the men who went with me, Aner, Eshcol, and Mamre. They will take their share."

Notes

- a (13:1) Asshur: the Ethiopic is corrupt here; Charles read "Canaan." The tall oak is that of Gen 12:6 (Moreh), as read by the Greek version.
- b (13:8) The first day of the first month (about March 22, the new year) of the year 1954 from creation. Abram was seventy-five (Gen 12:4).
- c (13:10) Bealoth: a town in the south of Judah (Josh 15:24).
- d (13:12) Compare Num 13:22. Tanis is Zoan.
- e (13:22) Sellasar is Ellasar. Tergal reads as in the Greek form of Tidal (Gen 14:1). The valley of Siddim is the Dead Sea area.
- f (13:23) Adam is Admah.
- g (13:25) The text has a gap before this verse. The missing lines must have told how Abram pursued the kings and met Melchizedek (Gen 14:15–20). Some Jews were uneasy that Abraham paid tithes to an uncircumcised priest, and one solution was to identify Melchizedek with Shem.

Chapter 14

God's Covenant with Abram, and the Birth of Ishmael

[1] After these things, in the fourth year of this week, on the first day of the third month, the word of the Lord came to Abram in a dream: "Do not be afraid, Abram. I am your protector, and your reward will be very great."[a] [2] He said, "Lord, Lord, what will you give me, since I am going away childless, and the son of Maseq, the son of my female slave, is Eliezer of Damascus; he will be my heir, and to me you have given no offspring." [3] He answered him, "This man will not inherit from you. Your heir will be a child of your own body, and he will be the one who inherits." [4] He brought him outside and said to him, "Look toward heaven and count the stars, if you are able to count them." [5] He looked toward heaven and saw the stars. He said to him, "So will your descendants be." [6] He believed in the Lord, and it was counted to him as righteousness. [7] He said to him, "I am the Lord who brought you out of Ur of the Chaldeans, to give you the land of the Canaanites to possess forever, and I will be God to you and to your descendants

after you." [8] He said, "Lord, Lord, how will I know that I will inherit it?" [9] He said to him, "Take me a heifer three years old, a goat three years old, a sheep three years old, a turtledove, and a pigeon." [10] He took all these in the middle of the month, and lived by the oak of Mamre, near Hebron. [11] He built an altar there and sacrificed all of these animals, pouring their blood on the altar. He cut each animal in two and set the halves facing each other, but he left the birds uncut. [12] Birds came down on the pieces, and Abram drove them away and did not let the birds touch them. [13] When the sun had set, a trance fell on Abram, and a horror of great darkness fell on him, and he was told, "Know for certain that your descendants will be foreigners in a land that is not theirs, and they will be made slaves and afflicted for four hundred years.[b] [14] I will judge the nation they serve, and after that they will come out with great wealth. [15] You will go to your fathers in peace, and be buried at a good old age. [16] But in the fourth generation they will return here, for the wrongdoing of the Amorites is not yet complete."[c] [17] He woke from his sleep and got up, and the sun had set, and there was a flame, and a smoking furnace, and a flame of fire passed between the pieces. [18] On that day the Lord made a covenant with Abram, saying, "To your descendants I will give this land, from the river of Egypt to the great river, the river Euphrates: the Kenites, Kenizzites, Kadmonites, Perizzites, Rephaim, Phakorites, Hivites, Amorites, Canaanites, Girgashites, and Jebusites." [19] The day passed, and Abram offered the pieces and the birds, with their grain offerings and drink offerings, and the fire consumed them. [20] On that day we made a covenant with Abram, as we had made a covenant with Noah in this month, and Abram renewed the festival and ordinance for himself forever.[d] [21] Abram rejoiced and told all these things to his wife Sarai, and he believed he would have offspring, but she did not bear. [22] Sarai advised her husband Abram and said to him, "Go in to my Egyptian slave Hagar; perhaps I will build up descendants for you through her." [23] Abram obeyed what his wife Sarai said and told her, "Do it." So Sarai took Hagar, her Egyptian servant, and gave her to her husband Abram as a wife. [24] He went in to her, and she

conceived and bore him a son, and he named him Ishmael, in the fifth year of this week; this was the eighty-sixth year of Abram's life.[e]

Notes

- a (14:1) First day of the third month: about May 22. The covenant itself is made on the fifteenth day of the same month (verses 10 and 20), the day of the Feast of Weeks (about June 5).
- b (14:13) Four hundred years: Gen 15:13. Exod 12:40 has 430, and Paul counts 430 from the promise (Gal 3:17). In Jubilees the four hundred years run from the birth of Isaac.
- c (14:16) A generation here is a hundred years.
- d (14:20) On that day: the fifteenth of the third month (see 6:17–22), the Feast of Weeks.
- e (14:24) The year 1965 from creation.

Chapter 15

The Feast of First Fruits, Circumcision, and the Promise of Isaac

1 In the fifth year of the fourth week of this jubilee, in the third month, in the middle of the month, Abram celebrated the feast of the first fruits of the grain harvest.[a] 2 He offered new offerings on the altar, the first fruits of the produce, to the Lord: a heifer, a goat, and a sheep on the altar as a burnt offering to the Lord; he offered their grain offerings and drink offerings on the altar with frankincense. 3 The Lord appeared to Abram and said to him, "I am God Almighty; show yourself faithful before me and be perfect. 4 I will make my covenant between me and you, and I will multiply you greatly." 5 Abram fell on his face, and God talked with him and said, 6 "See, my ordinance is with you, and you will be the father of many nations. 7 You will no longer be called Abram, but from now on your name, forever, will be Abraham, for I have made you the father of many nations.[b] 8 I will make you very great, and make you into nations, and kings will come out of you. 9 I will establish my covenant between me and you, and your descendants after you, through their generations, as an eternal covenant, so that I may be God to you and to your descendants after you. 10 I will give you and your descendants after you the land where you have been a stranger, the land of Canaan, to possess forever, and I will be their God." 11 The Lord said to Abraham, "As for you, keep

my covenant, you and your descendants after you. Circumcise every male among you, circumcise your foreskins, and it will be the sign of an eternal covenant between me and you. 12 You will circumcise the child on the eighth day, every male through your generations, whether born in the house or bought with money from any foreigner, anyone you have acquired who is not of your descendants.[c] 13 The one born in your house will certainly be circumcised, and those you buy with money will be circumcised, and my covenant will be in your flesh as an eternal ordinance. 14 The uncircumcised male who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin on the eighth day will be cut off from his people, for he has broken my covenant." 15 God said to Abraham, "As for your wife Sarai, her name will no longer be called Sarai; Sarah will be her name.[d] 16 I will bless her, and give you a son by her, and I will bless him, and he will become a nation, and kings of nations will come from him." 17 Abraham fell facedown and rejoiced. He thought to himself, "Can a man who is a hundred years old have a son, and can Sarah, at ninety years old, give birth?" 18 Abraham said to God, "If only Ishmael might live before you!" 19 God said, "Yes, and Sarah also will bear you a son, and you will name him Isaac, and I will establish my covenant with him, an everlasting covenant, and with his descendants after him.[e] 20 As for Ishmael also, I have heard you, and I will bless him and make him great and multiply him greatly, and he will father twelve princes, and I will make him a great nation. 21 But I will establish my covenant with Isaac, whom Sarah will bear you, in these days, in the next year." 22 He stopped speaking with him, and God went up from Abraham. 23 Abraham did what God had told him. He took his son Ishmael, all who had been born in his household, and all he had purchased, every male of his house, and circumcised the flesh of their foreskins. 24 On that very day Abraham was circumcised, and all the men of his house, those born in the house and all those he had bought with money from foreigners were circumcised with him. 25 This law is for all generations forever, and there is no postponing the circumcision, and no skipping one day out of the eight; for it is an eternal ordinance, ordained and written on the heavenly tablets. 26 Every male who is born and whose foreskin is not circumcised on

the eighth day does not belong to the children of the covenant that the Lord made with Abraham, but to the children of destruction; nor is there any mark on him that he is the Lord's; he is destined to be destroyed and killed from the earth, and rooted out of the earth, for he has broken the covenant of the Lord our God. 27 All the angels of the presence and all the angels of holiness have been made like this since the day they were created, and in front of them he consecrated Israel, so that Israel would be with him and with his holy angels.[f] 28 Tell the Israelites to keep the sign of this covenant in every generation as a perpetual law, and they will never be uprooted from the land. 29 For the command is ordained as a covenant, to be kept forever among all the Israelites. 30 The Lord did not bring Ishmael, his sons, his brothers, and Esau near to himself, and he did not choose them, though they are Abraham's children, because he knew them; but he chose Israel to be his people. 31 He made them holy and gathered them from all of humankind; for there are many nations and many peoples, and all are his, and over all he has placed spirits in authority to lead them astray from him.[g] 32 Over Israel, though, he set no angel and no spirit as ruler, because he alone governs them. He himself will guard them and call them to account at the hands of his angels, his spirits, and all his hosts, so that he keeps them and blesses them, and so that they belong to him and he to them, now and always. 33 I now tell you that the Israelites will prove unfaithful to this law. They will not circumcise their sons in keeping with all this law; they will leave out circumcision of the flesh for their sons, and all of them, sons of Beliar, will leave their sons uncircumcised, just as they were born.[h] 34 There will be great wrath from the Lord against the Israelites, because they have abandoned his covenant, turned aside from his word, provoked and blasphemed, since they do not keep the ordinance of this law; for they have treated their members like the nations, so that they will be removed and rooted out of the land. There will be no more pardon or forgiveness for them, for all the sin of this eternal error.

Notes

- a (15:1) The “fourth” week should read “third” (Charles). The middle of the third month is the fifteenth, the Feast of Weeks (about June 5). The Pharisees counted the feast differently, on the sixth of Sivan.
- b (15:7) Abraham: understood as “father of a multitude.”
- c (15:12) Jubilees insists on the eighth day, as in the Greek and Samaritan texts of Gen 17:14.
- d (15:15) Sarah: “princess.”
- e (15:19) Isaac: “he laughs.”
- f (15:27) The two highest ranks of angels share with Israel the keeping of the sabbath (2:18–21) and, here, circumcision; they were “created circumcised.”
- g (15:31) Compare Deut 32:8–9 in the Greek version, where the nations are assigned to “angels of God.” Seventy nations were put under seventy angels, but Israel under none (verse 32); compare Dan 10:13, 20–21, where Michael is Israel’s prince.
- h (15:33) Beliar: another form of Belial, “worthless”; here a name of the chief evil spirit. The author seems to be writing in a time when many Jews abandoned circumcision (the age of Antiochus Epiphanes, c. 170 BC).

Chapter 16

The Promise Renewed, Sodom Destroyed, and Isaac Born

1 On the first day of the fourth month we appeared to Abraham at the
oak of Mamre and talked with him, and told him that a son would
be given him by his wife Sarah.[a] 2 Sarah laughed, for she heard that
we had said these words to Abraham, and we warned her, and she
became afraid and denied that she had laughed at the words. 3 We
named her son for her, as his name stands decreed and written on the
heavenly tablets: Isaac. 4 We also said that when we came back to her
at the appointed time, she would be carrying a son. 5 In this month the
Lord carried out his judgments on Sodom, Gomorrah, Zeboim, and
the whole region of the Jordan, and burned them with fire and sulfur
and destroyed them to this day, as I have told you all their deeds: that
they are exceedingly wicked and sinful, and defile themselves and
commit fornication in their flesh, and work uncleanness on the earth.
6 In the same way God will execute judgment on the places where
they do the same uncleanness as the Sodomites, like the judgment of
Sodom. 7 But we saved Lot, for God remembered Abraham and sent
him out from the middle of the overthrow. 8 He and his daughters
committed a sin on the earth such as had not been on the earth from

the days of Adam until his time; for the man lay with his daughters. [9] It was commanded and engraved on the heavenly tablets concerning all his descendants to remove them and root them out, and to execute judgment on them like the judgment of Sodom, and to leave no descendant of the man on earth on the day of condemnation.[b] [10] In this month Abraham moved from Hebron, and went and lived between Kadesh and Shur, in the mountains of Gerar. [11] In the middle of the fifth month he moved from there and lived at the Well of the Oath.[c] [12] In the middle of the sixth month the Lord visited Sarah and did to her as he had said, and she conceived. [13] She bore a son in the third month, in the middle of the month, at the time the Lord had told Abraham, on the festival of the first fruits of the harvest, and Isaac was born.[d] [14] Abraham circumcised his son on the eighth day. He was the first to be circumcised according to the covenant ordained forever. [15] In the sixth year of the fourth week we came to Abraham at the Well of the Oath, and appeared to him. [16] We blessed him and told him everything that had been decreed about him: that he would not die until he fathered six more sons and saw them before he died, but that his name and descendants would be called in Isaac.[e] [17] All the descendants of his other sons would be Gentiles and be counted with the Gentiles; but from the sons of Isaac one would become a holy line, and would not be counted among the Gentiles. [18] For he would become the portion of the Most High, and all his descendants would fall into God's possession, to be a people for the Lord's own possession above all nations, a kingdom, priests, and a holy nation.[f] [19] We went on our way and told Sarah all that we had told him, and they both rejoiced with very great joy. [20] He built an altar there to the Lord, who had rescued him and made him rejoice in the land where he stayed as a stranger, and he celebrated a festival of joy in this month for seven days, near the altar he had built at the Well of the Oath.[g] [21] He built booths for himself and his servants for this festival, and he was the first to celebrate the Feast of Tabernacles on earth. [22] During these seven days he brought a burnt offering to the altar each day for the Lord: two oxen, two rams, seven sheep, and one male goat as a sin offering, to make atonement for himself and his descendants. [23] And

as a thank offering: seven rams, seven kids, seven sheep, and seven male goats, with their grain offerings and drink offerings; he burned all their fat on the altar, a chosen offering to the Lord for a pleasing fragrance. 24 Morning and evening he burned fragrant substances: frankincense, galbanum, stacte, nard, myrrh, spice, and costum. He offered all seven, ground and mixed together in equal parts, pure. 25 He kept this feast for seven days, rejoicing with all his heart and soul, he and all those in his house; there was no foreigner with him, and no one uncircumcised. 26 He blessed his Creator, who had made him in his generation, for he had made him according to his good pleasure; for he knew and saw that from him would rise the plant of righteousness for the eternal generations, and a holy line from him, so that it would become like him who made all things.[h] 27 He blessed and rejoiced, and called this festival the festival of the Lord, a joy acceptable to the Most High God. 28 We blessed him without end, and all the offspring who would come after him, in every generation of the earth, since he had kept this feast in its proper season, as the heavenly tablets testify. 29 For this reason it is ordained on the heavenly tablets concerning Israel that they celebrate the Feast of Tabernacles for seven days with joy, in the seventh month, acceptable before the Lord: a statute forever through their generations, every year.[i] 30 To this there is no limit of days; it is ordained forever for Israel that they celebrate it, live in booths, put wreaths on their heads, and take leafy branches and willows from the brook. 31 Abraham took palm branches and the fruit of fine trees, and every day he went around the altar with the branches seven times in the morning, and praised and thanked his God for everything with joy.[j]

Notes

- a (16:1) First day of the fourth month: about June 21. Compare Gen 18.
- b (16:9) The descendants of Lot are Moab and Ammon (Gen 19:37–38).
- c (16:11) The Well of the Oath is Beersheba (Gen 21:31). The middle of the fifth month is about August 5.
- d (16:13) In the middle of the third month, the Feast of Weeks (about June 5), in the year 1987 from creation. Charles and others noted that the sixth month is actually meant, so the pregnancy is nine months.

- e (16:16) Charles saw bracketed words here as a later insertion. The six sons are by Keturah (Gen 25:2).
- f (16:18) Compare Exod 19:5–6. The Hebrew text has "a kingdom of priests"; Jubilees has a form closer to Rev 1:6; 5:10.
- g (16:20) Verses 20–31 describe the origin of the Feast of Tabernacles, with several features of its own.
- h (16:26) The plant of righteousness: compare 1 Enoch 10:16; 93:5, 10.
- i (16:29) Seventh month: the fifteenth day is about October 4. Compare Lev 23:34–43.
- j (16:31) In later Jewish practice, the seven circuits of the altar were made only on the seventh day.

Chapter 17

Hagar and Ishmael Sent Away, and Mastema's Challenge

1 In the first year of the fifth week, in this jubilee, Isaac was weaned, and Abraham gave a great banquet in the third month, on the day his son Isaac was weaned.[a] 2 Ishmael, the son of Hagar the Egyptian, stood in front of his father Abraham in his place. Abraham was glad and blessed God, since he had lived to see his sons and had not died without children. 3 He remembered the words God had spoken to him on the day Lot left him, and he rejoiced because the Lord had given him descendants on the earth to inherit the earth, and he blessed the Creator of all things with his whole mouth. 4 Sarah watched Ishmael play and dance, and Abraham delighted in him. She grew jealous and said to Abraham, "Drive out this slave girl and her son. The slave girl's son will never share the inheritance with my son Isaac."[b] 5 This was hard for Abraham, because of his female slave and because of his son, that he should send them away from him. 6 God said to Abraham, "Do not let it be hard for you because of the boy and the slave woman. In everything Sarah has said to you, listen to her words and do them, for in Isaac your name and descendants will be called. 7 But as for the son of this slave woman, I will make him a great nation, because he is of your descendants." 8 Abraham got up early in the morning and took bread and a skin of water, put them on the shoulders of Hagar and the boy, and sent her away. 9 She left and wandered in the desert of Beersheba, and the water in the skin ran out, and the boy was thirsty and could not go on, and he fell down. 10 His mother took him and

threw him under an olive tree, and went and sat down opposite him, a bowshot away, for she said, "Let me not see my child die," and as she sat she wept. 11 An angel of God, one of the holy ones, said to her, "Why are you weeping, Hagar? Get up, take the boy and hold him by the hand, for God has heard your voice and seen the boy." 12 She opened her eyes, and saw a well of water, and went and filled her skin with water and gave her child a drink; she got up and went toward the desert of Paran. 13 The boy grew and became an archer, and God was with him. His mother took him a wife from the daughters of Egypt. 14 She bore him a son, and he named him Nebaioth, for she said, "The Lord was near me when I called on him."[c] 15 In the seventh week, in its first year, in the first month of this jubilee, on the twelfth of the month, there were voices in heaven about Abraham, that he was faithful in all that God told him, that he loved the Lord, and that in every affliction he was faithful.[d] 16 Prince Mastema came and said before God, "See, Abraham loves his son Isaac and delights in him above all else; tell him to offer him as a burnt offering on the altar, and you will see whether he will do this, and you will know if he is faithful in everything you test him with."[e] 17 The Lord knew that Abraham was faithful in all his afflictions, for he had tested him by his country, and with famine, and with the wealth of kings, and again through his wife, when she was taken from him, and with circumcision, and through Ishmael and Hagar his slave when he sent them away.[f] 18 In every trial he was found trustworthy. He did not grow impatient or hesitate to act, because he was loyal and loved the Lord.

Notes

- a (17:1) Isaac was weaned about the year 1989 from creation. The text says "fifth"; Charles read "fourth."
- b (17:4) Playing and dancing: the Greek and Latin of Gen 21:9 have "playing with her son Isaac." The word "dancing" in Jubilees may be a copyist's change.
- c (17:14) Nebaioth was Ishmael's eldest son (Gen 25:13). The explanation of the name here is not found in Genesis.
- d (17:15) The twelfth of the first month is about April 2, in the year 2003 from creation. By the book's own count, Isaac is twenty-three at the time (the Seder Olam rabbah says thirty-seven).
- e (17:16) In Genesis God himself tests Abraham (Gen 22:1); here it is Mastema's suggestion, as in Job 1–2.

- f (17:17) Seven of Abraham's ten traditional trials are named here. The others are Sarah's barrenness, the offering of Isaac, and the burial of Sarah; other lists differ slightly.

Chapter 18

The Offering of Isaac

1 God said to him, "Abraham, Abraham!" He said, "Here I am." 2 He said, "Take your beloved son Isaac, whom you love, and travel to the highlands. Offer him there on one of the mountains that I will show you." 3 He got up early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two young men with him, and his son Isaac, and split the wood for the burnt offering, and went to the place on the third day, and saw the place from far away. 4 He came to a well of water, and said to his young men, "Stay here with the donkey, and I and the boy will go over there, and when we have worshiped we will come back to you." 5 He took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on his son Isaac, and took in his hand the fire and the knife, and the two of them went together to that place. 6 Isaac said to his father, "Father," and he said, "Here I am, my son." He said to him, "Here are the fire, the knife, and the wood; but where is the sheep for the burnt offering, father?" 7 He said, "God will provide a sheep for himself for a burnt offering, my son." He came near to the place on the mount of God. 8 He built an altar and set the wood on it, and tied up his son Isaac and laid him on the wood on the altar, and stretched out his hand to take the knife to kill his son Isaac. 9 I stood before him, and before the prince Mastema, and the Lord said, "Tell him not to lay his hand on the boy or do anything to him, for I have shown that he fears the Lord."[a] 10 I called to him from heaven and said to him, "Abraham, Abraham!" and he was terrified and said, "Here I am." 11 I said to him, "Do not lay your hand on the boy and do not do anything to him, for now I have shown that you fear the Lord, and have not held back your son, your firstborn son, from me." 12 Prince Mastema was put to shame, and Abraham lifted his eyes and looked, and there was a single ram caught . . . by its horns, and Abraham went and took the ram and offered it as a burnt offering in place of his son.[b] 13 Abraham called that place "The Lord has seen," so that it is said, "On the mountain

the Lord has seen"; that is Mount Zion.[c] 14 The Lord called Abraham by his name a second time from heaven, as he made us appear to speak to him in the name of the Lord. 15 He said, "I have sworn by my own name, says the Lord: because you have done this and did not spare your son, your beloved son, I will surely bless you. I will make your descendants as many as the stars in the sky and the sand on the seashore. Your descendants will take over the cities of their enemies, 16 and in your descendants all the nations of the earth will be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice, and I have shown everyone that you are faithful to me in all I have said to you. Go in peace." 17 Abraham returned to his young men, and together they set out for Beersheba, and Abraham settled by the Well of the Oath. 18 He celebrated this festival every year, seven days with joy, and called it the festival of the Lord, after the seven days during which he went and returned in peace.[d] 19 So it has been ordained and written on the heavenly tablets concerning Israel and its descendants that they keep this festival seven days with festival joy.

Notes

- a (18:9) The speaker is the angel of the presence, who is narrating to Moses. "Mastema" here is probably a class name for evil spirits, and not only their prince. Compare 10:8.
- b (18:12) The text has a gap; Gen 22:13 adds "in a thicket."
- c (18:13) Mount Zion is identified with the mountain of Moriah, as in 2 Chron 3:1.
- d (18:18) The seven days: the Feast of Passover and Unleavened Bread (the fifteenth to the twenty-first of the first month, about April 5–11). Jubilees places Isaac's offering on the twelfth of the first month (17:15) and connects the seven days to the Passover season.

Chapter 19

Sarah's Death, Rebecca, and Abraham's Blessing of Jacob

1 In the first year of the first week of the forty-second jubilee, Abraham returned and lived opposite Hebron, that is, Kiriath Arba, for two weeks of years. 2 In the first year of the second week of this jubilee, the days of Sarah's life were completed, and she died in Hebron.[a] 3 Abraham went to grieve for her and bury her, and we put him to the test, to see whether his spirit was steady and whether he would

hold his tongue. He proved steady in this and was not shaken. 4 For
in patience of spirit he spoke with the Hittites, so that they would
give him a place to bury his dead. 5 The Lord gave him favor before
all who saw him, and he asked the Hittites gently, and they gave him
the land of the double cave opposite Mamre, that is, Hebron, for four
hundred pieces of silver.[b] 6 They begged him, saying, "We will give
it to you for nothing," but he would not take it from their hands for
nothing, for he paid the price of the place, the money in full, and he
bowed to them twice; after this he buried his dead in the double cave.
7 All the days of Sarah's life were a hundred and twenty-seven years,
that is, two jubilees, four weeks, and one year. These are the days of
Sarah's life. 8 This is the tenth trial with which Abraham was tested,
and he was found faithful and patient in spirit.[c] 9 He said nothing
at all about the rumor in the land that God had promised it to him and
his descendants. He begged for a burial place there for his dead. He
was found faithful and was written on the heavenly tablets as God's
friend.[d] 10 In the fourth year of this week he took a wife for his son
Isaac, named Rebecca, the sister of Laban and daughter of Bethuel;
Bethuel was the son of Melca, who was the wife of Nahor, Abraham's
brother. 11 Abraham took a third wife, named Keturah, from among
the daughters of his household servants, for Hagar had died before
Sarah.[e] 12 She bore him six sons: Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, Midian,
Ishbak, and Shuah, in the two weeks of years. 13 In the second year
of the sixth week, Rebecca bore Isaac two sons, Jacob and Esau.
Jacob was a smooth and upright man, and Esau was fierce, a man
of the field, and hairy, and Jacob lived in tents. 14 The boys grew up.
Jacob learned to write; Esau did not, for he was an outdoorsman and
a hunter. He learned warfare, and everything he did was savage.[f] 15
Abraham loved Jacob, but Isaac loved Esau. 16 Abraham saw Esau's
deeds, and knew that his name and descendants would be called in
Jacob. He called Rebecca and gave her instructions about Jacob, for
he knew that she also loved Jacob much more than Esau. 17 He said
to her, "My daughter, watch over my son Jacob, for he will be in my
place on the earth, a blessing among human beings and the glory of
all the descendants of Shem. 18 For I know that the Lord will choose

him to be a people for his own possession above all peoples on the face of the earth. [19] See, my son Isaac loves Esau more than Jacob, but I see that you truly love Jacob. [20] Add still more to your kindness to him, and let your eyes be on him in love, for he will be a blessing to us on the earth from now on through all generations of the earth. [21] May your hands be strong and your heart be glad in your son Jacob, whom I love far more than all my other sons. He will be blessed forever, and his offspring will fill the entire earth. [22] If a man can count the sand of the earth, his descendants also will be counted. [23] All the blessings with which the Lord has blessed me and my descendants will belong to Jacob and his descendants always. [24] In his descendants my name will be blessed, and the name of my fathers, Shem, Noah, Enoch, Mahalalel, Enos, Seth, and Adam.[g] [25] These will serve to lay the foundations of heaven, to strengthen the earth, and to renew all the lights in the sky." [26] He called Jacob before the eyes of his mother Rebecca, and kissed him and blessed him, and said, [27] "Jacob, my beloved son, whom my soul loves, may God bless you from above the firmament, and give you all the blessings with which he blessed Adam, Enoch, Noah, and Shem; and all the things he told me and all he promised to give me, may he make them stay with you and your descendants forever, as long as the days of heaven above the earth. [28] May the spirits of Mastema not rule over you or your descendants to turn you from the Lord, who is your God from now on forever. [29] May the Lord God be a father to you, and you the firstborn son, and to the people always. Go in peace, my son." [30] They both went out together from Abraham. [31] Rebecca loved Jacob with all her heart and all her soul, much more than Esau, but Isaac loved Esau much more than Jacob.

Notes

- a (19:2) The text says "third"; Charles read "second."
- b (19:5) The double cave is Machpelah (Gen 23).
- c (19:8) Compare 17:17 and the note there.
- d (19:9) "Friend of God": compare Isa 41:8 and Jas 2:23.
- e (19:11) This explains why Abraham did not take Hagar back. A later tradition identifies Hagar and Keturah.

- f (19:14) In the Aramaic Targums, the "tents" are schools. Jacob is portrayed throughout as a lifelong student of the law.
- g (19:24) Methuselah is left out of the list, and Adam is counted among the holy ancestors.

Chapter 20

Abraham's Last Instructions

1 In the first year of the sixth week of the forty-second jubilee, Abraham called Ishmael and his twelve sons, Isaac and his two sons, and the six sons of Keturah and their sons.[a] 2 He commanded them to keep the way of the Lord, to practice righteousness, to love their neighbors, and to act this way among all people; each of them was to walk so as to do justice and righteousness on the earth. 3 They were to circumcise their sons, according to the covenant he had made with them, and not turn to the right or left from any of the paths the Lord had commanded us; and we were to keep ourselves from all fornication and uncleanness.[b] 4 If any woman or girl commits fornication among you, burn her with fire, and do not let them commit fornication with her in their eyes and hearts; and do not let them take wives from the daughters of Canaan, for the descendants of Canaan will be rooted out of the land.[c] 5 He spoke to them about the judgment on the giants and on the people of Sodom, how they were condemned for their wickedness and died for their sexual immorality, impurity, and corrupting one another. 6 "Guard yourselves from all fornication and uncleanness and every pollution of sin, or you will make our name a curse and your whole life a laughingstock, and all your sons will be destroyed by the sword, and you will become cursed like Sodom and all your remnant like the sons of Gomorrah. 7 I beg you, my sons: love the God of heaven and hold on to all his commandments. Do not walk after their idols and their uncleanness. 8 Do not make molten or carved gods for yourselves, for they are empty, and there is no spirit in them; they are the work of human hands, and all who trust in them trust in nothing. Do not serve them or worship them. 9 Serve the Most High God and worship him continually; hope always for his face, and practice uprightness and righteousness before him, so that he will take pleasure in you and give you his mercy, and send

you rain morning and evening, and bless all the work you do on the earth, and bless your bread and your water, the fruit of your womb and the fruit of your land, the herds of your cattle and the flocks of your sheep. 10 You will be a blessing on the earth, and all the nations of the earth will desire you and bless their sons in my name, so that they may be blessed as I am." 11 He gave gifts to Ishmael and his sons, and to the sons of Keturah, and sent them away from his son Isaac, and he gave everything to his son Isaac. 12 Ishmael and his sons, and the sons of Keturah and their sons, went together and settled from Paran to the entrance of Babylon, in all the land east of there facing the desert. 13 They mingled with each other, and their name was called Arabs and Ishmaelites.

Notes

- a (20:1) The text says "seventh"; Charles read "sixth."
- b (20:3) Circumcision is binding also on the descendants of Ishmael and Keturah; Esau's line is left out.
- c (20:4) The law of Moses prescribes burning only for a priest's daughter (Lev 21:9); in other cases, stoning.

Chapter 21

Abraham's Last Words to Isaac

1 In the sixth year of the seventh week of this jubilee, Abraham called his son Isaac and commanded him, saying, "I have become old and do not know the day of my death; I am full of my days.[a] 2 I am a hundred and seventy-five years old, and all the days of my life I have remembered the Lord, and have sought with all my heart to do his will and to walk uprightly in all his ways. 3 My soul has hated idols, and I have despised those who served them, and I have given my heart and spirit to observe the will of him who made me. 4 For he is the living God, holy and faithful, and he is righteous beyond all, and with him there is no favoritism and no accepting of gifts, for God is righteous and executes judgment on all who transgress his commandments and despise his covenant. 5 You, my son, keep his commandments, ordinances, and judgments, and do not walk after the abominations, the carved images, and the molten images. 6 Do not eat any blood of animals or livestock, or of any bird that flies

in the sky. 7 When you slaughter an animal as an acceptable peace
offering, do so and pour its blood over the altar. Burn all the offering's
fat on the altar together with fine flour, the grain offering mixed with
oil, and its drink offering, all of it on the burnt-offering altar. It is a
fragrance pleasing to the Lord. 8 You will offer the fat of the thank
offering on the fire that is on the altar: the fat on the belly, all the fat
on the inner parts, and the two kidneys and all the fat on them, and
on the loins; and you will remove the liver along with the kidneys.
9 Offer all these as a pleasing fragrance, acceptable before the Lord,
with its grain offering and drink offering, the bread of the offering
to the Lord. 10 Eat the meat that day and the next, but before the sun
sets on the second day it must be eaten. Leave nothing for the third
day, because then it is unacceptable and may not be eaten anymore,
and whoever eats it will load sin on himself. This is what I found
written in my ancestors' books, in Enoch's words, and in Noah's.[b] 11
On all offerings you will sprinkle salt, and do not let the salt of the
covenant be missing from any of your offerings before the Lord. 12 As
for the wood of the sacrifices, be careful not to bring any other wood
to the altar except these: cypress, dafran, sagad, pine, fir, cedar, savin,
palm, olive, myrtle, laurel, citron, juniper, and balsam.[c] 13 From these
woods, put on the altar beneath the sacrifice only pieces that have
been checked for appearance. Do not lay cracked or dark wood on it,
but hard, clean, flawless, sound wood from fresh growth. Do not lay
old wood there, since its scent is gone; it no longer smells as it once
did. 14 Besides these woods there is no other that you may place on the
altar, for the fragrance is dispersed, and the smell of its fragrance does
not go up to heaven. 15 Keep this commandment and do it, my son, so
that you may be upright in all your deeds. 16 At all times be clean in
your body, and wash yourself with water before you approach to offer
on the altar, and wash your hands and feet before you come near the
altar; when you are done sacrificing, wash your hands and feet again.
17 Let no blood appear on you or on your clothes. Guard yourself, my
son, against blood, be very careful; cover it with dust. 18 Do not eat
any blood, for it is the soul; eat no blood at all. 19 Take no gifts for
human blood, or it will be shed with impunity, without judgment;

for it is shed blood that makes the earth sin, and the earth cannot be cleansed from human blood except by the blood of the one who shed it. [20] Take no present or gift for human blood: blood for blood, so that you may be accepted before the Lord, the Most High God; for he is the defense of the good; so that you may be kept from all evil, and he may save you from every kind of death. [21] I see, my son, that all the works of human beings are sin and wickedness, and all their deeds are uncleanness, an abomination, and a pollution, and there is no righteousness in them. [22] Take care not to walk in their ways and tread their paths, and not to commit a sin unto death before the Most High God, or he will hide his face from you and give you back into the hands of your transgression, and root you out of the land, and your descendants likewise from under heaven, and your name and your descendants will vanish from the whole earth. [23] Turn away from all their deeds and all their uncleanness, and keep the ordinance of the Most High God, and do his will and be upright in all things. [24] He will bless you in all your deeds, and will raise up from you the plant of righteousness through all the earth, throughout all generations of the earth, and my name and your name will not be forgotten under heaven forever. [25] Go, my son, in peace. May the Most High God, my God and yours, strengthen you to do his will, and may he bless all your descendants and the rest of your descendants through the generations forever, with all righteous blessings, so that you may be a blessing on all the earth." [26] He went out from him rejoicing.

Notes

- a (21:1) The text says "seventh"; Charles read "sixth." These words are Isaac's in Gen 27:2. The rest of the chapter gives Abraham's directions to Isaac on sacrifice, a parallel to Testament of Levi 9, where Isaac teaches Levi.
- b (21:10) These rules about the sacrificial meat are not found in the surviving writings of Enoch or Noah.
- c (21:12) Fourteen kinds of wood. The Mishnah allows any wood except olive and vine. Dafran and sagad are unknown trees; the Ethiopic words are transcribed.

Chapter 22

Abraham's Last Feast, Prayer, and Blessing of Jacob

1 In the first week of the forty-second jubilee, in the sixth year, the
year Abraham died, Isaac and Ishmael came from the Well of the
Oath to celebrate the Feast of Weeks, the harvest feast of first fruits,
with their father Abraham. Abraham was glad that both his sons had
come.[a] 2 Isaac had many possessions in Beersheba, and he used to
go and see his possessions and return to his father. 3 At that time
Ishmael came to visit his father. The two came together, and Isaac
presented a burnt offering on his father's altar, the one Abraham had
built in Hebron. 4 He offered a thank offering and made a feast of
joy before his brother Ishmael, and Rebecca made new cakes from
the new grain and gave them to her son Jacob to take to his father
Abraham, from the first fruits of the land, so that he could eat and
bless the Creator of all things before he died. 5 Isaac also sent by
Jacob's hand to Abraham a fine thank offering, so that he could eat
and drink. 6 He ate and drank, and blessed the Most High God, who
made heaven and earth, who made all the rich things of the earth
and gave them to human beings, so that they could eat and drink and
bless their Creator. 7 "Now I give thanks to you, my God, because you
have let me see this day. Look, I am a hundred and seventy-five years
old, an old man and full of days, and all my days have been peace
to me. 8 The sword of the enemy has not overcome me in anything
you gave me and my children all the days of my life to this day. 9
My God, may your mercy and your peace be on your servant and
on the descendants of his sons, so that they may be a chosen nation
and an inheritance for you from among all the nations of the earth
from now on through all the days of the generations of the earth,
through all the ages." 10 He called Jacob and said, "My son Jacob, may
the God of all bless you and strengthen you to do righteousness and
his will before him, and may he choose you and your descendants
to be a people for his inheritance according to his will always. Come
near, my son Jacob, and kiss me." 11 He came near and kissed him,
and Abraham said, "Blessed be my son Jacob and all the sons of God
Most High, through all the ages. May God give you a righteous line,
and may he make some of your sons holy in the middle of the whole
earth. May nations serve you, and all the nations bow down to your

descendants.[b] 12 Be strong in the presence of people, and rule over all
the descendants of Seth. Then your ways and your sons' ways will
be justified, so that they become a holy nation.[c] 13 May the Most High
God give you all the blessings with which he blessed me and with
which he blessed Noah and Adam; may they rest on the holy head
of your descendants from generation to generation forever. 14 May
he cleanse you from all unrighteousness and impurity, so that you
may be forgiven all your transgressions and your sins of ignorance.
May he strengthen you and bless you, and may you inherit the whole
earth. 15 May he renew his covenant with you, so that you may be a
nation for his inheritance for all the ages, and so that he may be to
you and your descendants a God in truth and righteousness through
all the days of the earth. 16 You, my son Jacob, remember my words and
keep the commandments of Abraham your father: separate yourself
from the nations, do not eat with them, do not act as they do, and do
not become their partner, for their works are unclean, and all their
ways are a pollution, an abomination, and uncleanness.[d] 17 They offer
sacrifices to the dead and worship evil spirits, and eat over the graves,
and all their works are vanity and nothingness. 18 They lack the mind
to understand, and their eyes cannot see their own deeds or how they
go astray, telling a block of wood, 'You are my God,' and a stone, 'You
are my Lord, you save me.' 19 As for you, my son Jacob, may the Most
High God help you, and the God of heaven bless you and remove
you from their uncleanness and all their error. 20 Be careful, my son
Jacob, not to take a wife from any of the daughters of Canaan, for all
his descendants are to be rooted out of the earth. 21 For, because of
the transgression of Ham, Canaan erred, and all his descendants will
be destroyed from the earth with all the rest of them, and none who
come from him will be saved on the day of judgment. 22 And all the
worshipers of idols and the profane will have no hope in the land of
the living; there will be no remembrance of them on the earth, for
they will go down to Sheol and into the place of condemnation. As
the children of Sodom were taken from the earth, so all who worship
idols will be taken away. 23 Do not be afraid, my son Jacob, and do
not be dismayed, son of Abraham. May the Most High God keep you

from destruction, and deliver you from all the paths of error. 24 I built this house for myself, to put my name on it on the earth; it is given to you and your descendants forever, and it will be named the house of Abraham; it is given to you and your descendants forever; for you will build my house and establish my name before God forever; your descendants and your name will stand through all generations of the earth."[e] 25 He stopped commanding him and blessing him. 26 The two of them lay down together in one bed. Jacob slept against the chest of his grandfather Abraham, who kissed him seven times, his heart and his love glad over the boy. 27 He blessed him with all his heart and said, "The Most High God, the God of all, Creator of all, who brought me out of Ur of the Chaldeans to give me this land to inherit forever, and so that I might establish a holy line: blessed be the Most High forever." 28 He blessed Jacob and said, "My son, over whom I rejoice with all my heart and love, may your grace and mercy be lifted up on him and on his descendants always. 29 Do not abandon him or treat him as nothing from now on to the days of eternity, and may your eyes be opened on him and on his descendants, so that you will protect him, and bless him, and make him holy as a nation for your inheritance. 30 Bless him with all your blessings from now to all the days of eternity, and renew your covenant and your grace with him and with his descendants according to all your good pleasure through all the generations of the earth."

Notes

- a (22:1) The text reads "forty-fourth jubilee … second year"; Charles read "forty-second … sixth." Abraham died in 2109 from creation, at 175 (see 23:8). Feast of Weeks: the fifteenth of the third month, about June 5.
- b (22:11) Compare Gen 27:29.
- c (22:12) All the descendants of Seth: all humankind.
- d (22:16) "Do not eat with them" was a key question in the time of the Maccabees (1 Macc 1:62–63; Dan 1:8).
- e (22:24) "House" here means "family."

Chapter 23

Abraham's Death, Shorter Lives, and the Last Days

1 He placed two of Jacob's fingers on his eyes, and blessed the God of
gods, and covered his face, stretched out his feet, slept the sleep of
eternity, and was gathered to his fathers. 2 In spite of all this, Jacob
lay in his bosom and did not know that his father's father Abraham
was dead. 3 Jacob woke from his sleep and found Abraham cold as ice,
and said, "Father, father!" but no one answered, and he knew that he
was dead. 4 He got up from his bosom and ran and told his mother
Rebecca. Rebecca went to Isaac in the night and told him, and they
went together, with Jacob, and a lamp in his hand, and when they
went in they found Abraham lying dead. 5 Isaac fell on his father's
face and wept and kissed him. 6 The voices were heard in Abraham's
house, and his son Ishmael got up and went to his father Abraham
and wept over him, he and the whole house of Abraham, and they
wept with a great weeping. 7 His sons Isaac and Ishmael buried him
in the double cave, near his wife Sarah, and they mourned him forty
days, all the men of his house, Isaac and Ishmael and all their sons,
and all the sons of Keturah in their places; and the days of weeping
for Abraham ended. 8 He lived three jubilees and four weeks of years,
a hundred and seventy-five years, and completed the days of his life,
old and full of days.[a] 9 For the days of the forefathers' lives were
nineteen jubilees; and after the flood they began to be fewer than
nineteen jubilees, and to shrink in jubilees, and to grow old quickly
and be full of their days because of many troubles and the wickedness
of their ways, except for Abraham.[b] 10 For Abraham was perfect in all
his deeds with the Lord and pleasing in righteousness all the days
of his life; yet he did not complete four jubilees in his life, when he
had grown old because of the wickedness, and was full of his days. 11
Every generation arising between now and the great day of judgment
will age rapidly, before reaching even two jubilees, and old age will
strip away their understanding. 12 In those days, if a person lives a
jubilee and a half of years, they will say of him, "He has lived long,"
and most of his days are pain, sorrow, and trouble, with no peace.[c] 13
For calamity follows calamity, wound follows wound, trouble follows
trouble, and bad news follows bad news, illness follows illness, and all
such evil judgments one after another: illness and overthrow, snow,

frost, and ice, fever, chills, numbness, famine, death, sword, captivity,
and all kinds of calamities and pains. 14 All these will come on an evil
generation that transgresses on the earth; their works are uncleanness and fornication, pollution and abominations. 15 Then they will
say, “The days of the forefathers were many, even up to a thousand
years, and were good; but see, the days of our life, if a person has
lived long, are seventy years, or if he is strong, eighty, and those
are evil, and there is no peace in the days of this evil generation.”[d]
16 In that generation the sons will convict their fathers and elders of
sin and unrighteousness, of the words of their mouths and the great
wickedness they commit, and of their abandoning the covenant that
the Lord made between them and himself, that they should keep and
do all his commandments, ordinances, and laws, without turning to
the right or the left. 17 For all have done evil, every mouth speaks
injustice, and all their works are uncleanness and abomination, and
all their ways are pollution, uncleanness, and destruction. 18 The earth
will be destroyed because of all their works; there will be no fruit of
the vine and no oil, for their works are altogether faithless; and they
will all perish together, animals, livestock, birds, and all the fish of
the sea, because of human beings. 19 They will fight each other, the
young against the old, the old against the young, the poor against the
rich, the lowly against the great, the beggar against the prince, over
the law and the covenant; for they have forgotten the commandment,
the covenant, the feasts, the months, the sabbaths, the jubilees, and
all judgments. 20 They will stand with bows, swords, and war to turn
them back into the way, but they will not turn back until much blood
has been shed on the earth, one by another. 21 The survivors will not
turn back from their evil to the road of justice. All of them will puff
themselves up with fraud and wealth, each seizing whatever belongs
to his neighbor. They will invoke the great name, but not truthfully
or justly, and will defile the most holy place with their impurity and
the corruption of their pollution. 22 A great punishment will come on
the deeds of this generation from the Lord, and he will hand them
over to the sword, to judgment, to captivity, and to being plundered
and devoured. 23 He will rouse the sinful nations against them, who

have no mercy or compassion, and who will show favor to no one, old or young, for they are more wicked and strong to do evil than all humankind. They will use violence against Israel and transgression against Jacob, and much blood will be shed on the earth, and there will be none to gather the dead and none to bury them. [24] In those days they will cry aloud, and call and pray to be saved from the hand of the sinners, the Gentiles, but none will be saved. [25] The heads of the children will be white with gray hair, and a child of three weeks will look as old as a man of a hundred, and their stature will be destroyed by trouble and oppression. [26] In those days the children will begin to study the laws, to seek the commandments, and to return to the path of righteousness.[e] [27] The days will begin to grow many and increase among those human beings, until their days draw near a thousand years, and to a greater number of years than the number of days before. [28] There will be no old man, nor anyone who is not satisfied with his days, for all will be like children and youths. [29] They will complete all their days and live in peace and joy, and there will be no Satan nor any evil destroyer, for all their days will be days of blessing and healing. [30] In that time the Lord will heal his servants. They will get up and enjoy deep peace, and drive out their enemies. The righteous will see it and give thanks and be glad forever, watching all his judgments and curses fall on their foes. [31] Their bones will rest in the earth, and their spirits will have much joy, and they will know that it is the Lord who executes judgment and shows mercy to hundreds and thousands and to all who love him. [32] And you, Moses, write down these words; for so they are written and recorded on the heavenly tablets as a testimony for the generations forever.

Notes

- a (23:8) 3 × 49 + 4 × 7 = 175. The year was 2109 from creation.
- b (23:9) Human life grows shorter as wickedness grows; compare 4 Ezra 5:50–55.
- c (23:12) A jubilee and a half is 73½ years; compare Ps 90:10, "seventy years, or eighty if we are strong."
- d (23:15) A picture of the troubles of the early second century BC, most likely the Hellenizing crisis before and during the Maccabean revolt (1 Macc 1–2).
- e (23:26) The text from here to verse 31 is a vision of a coming renewal. The people will not rise bodily; the righteous enjoy blessing while their bones rest in the earth

and their spirits rejoice (verse 31), as in 1 Enoch 91–104. "Gray hair on the temples of the newborn" (verse 25) is also a sign of the end times in Sibylline Oracles 2.155.

Chapter 24

Isaac at the Well of Vision, Esau's Birthright, and Gerar

1 After the death of Abraham the Lord blessed his son Isaac, and he left
Hebron and went and lived at the Well of the Vision, in the first year
of the third week of this jubilee, for seven years.[a] 2 A famine struck
the land in the first year of the fourth week, a different one from the
famine that came in Abraham's time. 3 Jacob boiled lentil stew, and
Esau came in from the field hungry. He said to his brother Jacob, "Give
me some of this red stew." Jacob said to him, "Sell me your birthright,
and I will give you bread, and some of this lentil stew too." 4 Esau said
in his heart, "I am going to die; what good is this birthright to me?"
and he said to Jacob, "I give it to you." 5 Jacob said, "Swear to me today,"
and he swore to him. 6 Jacob gave his brother Esau bread and stew,
and he ate until he was full, and Esau despised his birthright; for this
reason Esau's name was called Edom, because of the red stew that
Jacob gave him for his birthright.[b] 7 So Jacob became the elder and
Esau was brought down from his rank. 8 The famine lay over the land,
and in the second year of this week Isaac set out to go down to Egypt,
and went to Abimelech, the king of the Philistines, at Gerar. 9 The Lord
appeared to him and said, "Do not go down to Egypt. Live in the land
that I will tell you about, and stay in this land, and I will be with you
and bless you. 10 For to you and your descendants I will give all this
land, and I will establish my oath that I swore to your father Abraham,
and I will multiply your descendants like the stars of heaven, and give
your descendants all this land. 11 In your descendants all the nations
of the earth will be blessed, because your father obeyed my voice
and kept my charge, my commandments, my laws, my ordinances,
and my covenant; and now obey my voice and live in this land." 12
He lived in Gerar for three weeks of years.[c] 13 Abimelech gave orders
about him and about everything that was his, saying, "Any man who
touches him or anything of his will surely die." 14 Isaac grew strong
among the Philistines and gained many possessions, cattle, sheep,

camels, donkeys, and a large household. 15 He sowed in the land of the
Philistines and harvested a hundredfold, and Isaac became very great,
and the Philistines envied him. 16 Now all the wells that Abraham's
servants had dug in Abraham's lifetime, the Philistines had stopped
up after Abraham's death and filled with earth. 17 Abimelech said to
Isaac, "Leave us, for you are much stronger than we are," and Isaac left
there in the first year of the seventh week and stayed in the valleys of
Gerar. 18 They dug again the wells of water that his father Abraham's
servants had dug and that the Philistines had closed after the death
of his father Abraham, and he gave them the names that his father
Abraham had given them. 19 Isaac's servants dug a well in the valley
and found living water, and the shepherds of Gerar quarreled with
Isaac's shepherds, saying, "The water is ours." Isaac named the well
"Perversity," because they had been perverse with us.[d] 20 They dug a
second well, and they quarreled over that one too, and he named it
"Enmity." He moved on from there and they dug another well, and
over that one they did not quarrel, and he named it "Room." Isaac
said, "Now the Lord has made room for us, and we have increased in
the land."[e] 21 From there he went up to the Well of the Oath, in the
first year of the first week in the forty-fourth jubilee.[f] 22 That night,
on the first day of the first month, the Lord appeared to him and said,
"I am the God of your father Abraham. Fear nothing, because I am
with you. I will bless you, and for the sake of my servant Abraham I
will make your descendants as numerous as the grains of sand on the
earth."[g] 23 He built there an altar, which his father Abraham had first
built, and he called on the name of the Lord, and offered sacrifice to
the God of his father Abraham. 24 They dug a well and found living
water. 25 Isaac's servants dug another well but found no water. They
went and told Isaac they had found none, and Isaac said, "I made an
oath to the Philistines today, and so this has been brought upon us."[h]
26 He named that place the Well of the Oath, for there he had sworn
to Abimelech, to his friend Ahuzzath, and to Phicol the commander
of his army. 27 Isaac knew that day that he had sworn to them under
constraint, to make peace with them. 28 That day Isaac pronounced
a curse: "Cursed be the Philistines until the day of wrath and fury,

out of all the nations. May God make them a mockery and a curse, an object of rage and anger, in the hands of sinners, the Gentiles, and in the hands of the Kittim.[i] 29 Whoever escapes the sword of the enemy and the Kittim, may the righteous nation root out in judgment from under heaven; for they will be enemies and foes of my children through their generations on the earth. 30 No remnant will be left to them, and no one will be saved on the day of the wrath of judgment; for the whole seed of the Philistines is reserved for destruction, uprooting, and expulsion from the earth, and there will be left to these Caphtorim no name or descendants on the earth.[j] 31 Though he go up to heaven, he will be brought down from there; though he make himself strong on earth, he will be dragged out from there; though he hide among the nations, even from there he will be rooted out; though he go down to Sheol, there too his condemnation will be great, and there too he will have no peace. 32 If he goes into captivity, those who seek his life will kill him on the way, and neither name nor descendants will be left to him on all the earth, for he will depart into eternal curse." 33 So it stands written about him on the heavenly tablets, to be carried out against him on the day of judgment, so that he will be uprooted from the earth.

Notes

- a (24:1) Beer-lahai-roi, "the well of the Living One who sees me" (Gen 25:11).
- b (24:6) Edom means "red."
- c (24:12) Three weeks of years is twenty-one years. Charles's chronology puts this in 2080–2101 from creation.
- d (24:19) Hebrew Esek, "quarrel" (Gen 26:20).
- e (24:20) Hebrew Sitnah, "enmity," and Rehoboth, "open spaces" (Gen 26:21–22).
- f (24:21) Beersheba, "well of the oath" or "of seven."
- g (24:22) The new moon of the first month is the first day of the first month, about March 22, a Wednesday in this calendar.
- h (24:25) In the Hebrew of Gen 26:32 the servants say "we have found water"; the Greek reads as here. Here the failure to find water is read as a result of the oath made with Abimelech.
- i (24:28) The curse reflects the bitterness toward the Philistines in the Maccabean period, in which their coastal cities were attacked and taken. Kittim: originally Cyprus; later the western powers, Greeks and Romans.
- j (24:30) Caphtor, usually Crete, is named in Amos 9:7 as the Philistines' origin.

Chapter 25

Rebecca Warns Jacob and Blesses Him

1 In the second year of this week of this jubilee, Rebecca summoned
her son Jacob and told him, "My son, you must not marry one of
the Canaanite women, as your brother Esau did. He married two of
them, and they have made my life bitter with all their defiling ways.
Everything they do is sexual immorality and lust, and nothing about
them is just; their conduct is wicked. 2 I love you very much, my son,
and my heart and my affection bless you every hour of the day and
every watch of the night. 3 Now, my son, listen to my voice and do
your mother's will: do not take a wife from the daughters of this land,
but only from the house of my father and from my father's relatives.
You will take a wife from the house of my father, and the Most High
God will bless you, and your children will be a righteous generation
and a holy line." 4 Jacob said to his mother Rebecca, "Look, mother,
I am nine weeks of years old, and I have not known nor touched
any woman, nor have I betrothed myself to any, nor even thought of
taking a wife from the daughters of Canaan.[a] 5 I remember, Mother,
what our father Abraham told me: not to marry a Canaanite woman,
but to choose a wife from my father's house and from among my kin.
6 I have heard before that daughters have been born to your brother
Laban, and I have set my heart on them to take a wife from among
them. 7 That is why I have kept watch over my spirit all my life, so
that I do not sin or ruin any of my ways. Abraham my father gave me
many commands about lust and sexual immorality. 8 In spite of all he
commanded me, for these twenty-two years my brother has argued
with me, speaking to me often and saying, 'My brother, take a sister
of my two wives as your wife,' but I refuse to do as he has done. 9
Mother, I promise you that as long as I live I will never marry one of
the Canaanite women, and I will not behave wickedly as my brother
has. 10 Do not be afraid, mother; be assured that I will do your will and
walk in uprightness, and never corrupt my ways." 11 Then she raised
her face toward heaven, spread out her fingers, and opening her
mouth blessed God Most High, maker of heaven and earth, offering
him thanks and praise. 12 She said, "Blessed be the Lord God, and may

his holy name be blessed forever and ever, who has given me Jacob as a pure son and a holy line; for he is yours, and yours shall his descendants be continually and through all the generations forever. [13] Bless him, Lord, and put in my mouth the blessing of righteousness, so that I may bless him." [14] At that hour, when the spirit of righteousness came down into her mouth, she placed both her hands on Jacob's head and said,[b] [15] "Blessed are you, Lord of righteousness and God of the ages; may he bless you beyond all the generations of human beings. My son, may he give you the path of righteousness, and reveal righteousness to your descendants. [16] May he give you many sons in your lifetime; may they grow up as numerous as the months of the year; may their children be great and many, outnumbering the stars of heaven and the sand on the seashore.[c] [17] May he give them this good land, as he said he would give it to Abraham and his descendants after him always, and may they hold it as a possession forever. [18] May I see born to you, my son, blessed children during my life, and may all your descendants be a blessed and holy line. [19] As you have refreshed your mother's spirit during your life, the womb of her who bore you blesses you, my affection and my breasts bless you, and my mouth and my tongue praise you greatly. [20] Increase and spread over the earth, and may your descendants be perfect in the joy of heaven and earth forever, and may your descendants rejoice, and on the great day of peace may they have peace. [21] May your name and your descendants last through all the ages, and may the Most High God be their God, and the God of righteousness live with them, and may his sanctuary be built by them through all the ages. [22] Blessed be the one who blesses you, and may all flesh that falsely curses you be cursed." [23] She kissed him and said, "May the Lord of the world love you as the heart of your mother and her affection rejoice in you and bless you." And she stopped blessing.

Notes

- a (25:4) Nine weeks of years is 63. Genesis 25:26 says he was 60 at the twins' birth and does not give his age at the blessing; Jubilees counts his age by its own scheme.
- b (25:14) Some manuscripts read "Holy Spirit" here.
- c (25:16) Twelve sons, the twelve months of the year.

Chapter 26

Jacob Obtains the Firstborn's Blessing

1 In the seventh year of this week Isaac called his elder son Esau and
said to him, "I am old, my son, and see, my eyes are dim, and I do
not know the day of my death. 2 Now take your hunting weapons,
your quiver and bow, and go out to the field, and hunt and catch some
game for me, my son, and make me tasty food, such as my soul loves,
and bring it to me to eat, so that my soul may bless you before I die." 3
But Rebecca heard Isaac speaking to Esau. 4 Esau went out early to the
field to hunt and catch game and bring it home to his father. 5 Rebecca
called her son Jacob and said to him, "Look, I heard your father Isaac
speaking to your brother Esau, saying, 'Hunt for me, and make me
tasty food, and bring it to me so that I may eat and bless you before the
Lord before I die.' 6 Now, my son, obey my voice in what I command
you: go to your flock and bring me two good kids of the goats, and I
will make them into tasty food for your father, such as he loves, and
you will bring it to your father so that he may eat and bless you before
the Lord before he dies, and so that you may be blessed." 7 Jacob said
to his mother Rebecca, "Mother, I will not hold back anything my
father would eat and that would please him. I only fear, mother, that
he will recognize my voice and want to touch me. 8 You know that I
am smooth and my brother Esau is hairy, and I will look to his eyes
like a wrongdoer, and do something he did not command me, and he
will be angry with me, and I will bring on myself a curse and not a
blessing." 9 His mother Rebecca said to him, "Let your curse be on me,
my son; only obey my voice." 10 Jacob did as his mother Rebecca told
him. He went and fetched two fine, fat young goats and brought them
to his mother, who prepared them as a savory dish, just the way his
father loved it. 11 Rebecca took the fine garments that belonged to her
older son Esau and were kept in the house with her, and dressed her
younger son Jacob in them. She covered his hands and the smooth
part of his neck with the skins of the kids. 12 She gave the food and
the bread she had prepared into the hand of her son Jacob. 13 Jacob
went in to his father and said, "I am your son; I have done as you told
me. Get up, sit, and eat what I have caught, father, so that your soul

may bless me." 14 Isaac asked his son, "My son, how were you able to
find it so fast?" 15 Jacob said, "Because the Lord your God let me find
it." 16 Isaac said to him, "Come near, so that I may feel you, my son,
to see whether you are my son Esau or not." 17 Jacob went near to his
father Isaac, and he felt him, and said, 18 "The voice is Jacob's voice,
but the hands are the hands of Esau," and he did not recognize him,
because it was a turn of events from heaven to take away his power
of perception, and Isaac did not recognize him, for his hands were
hairy like his brother Esau's, so that he blessed him.[a] 19 He said, "Are
you my son Esau?" and he said, "I am your son." He said, "Bring it
near to me so that I may eat of what you have caught, my son, so
that my soul may bless you." 20 He brought it near to him and he ate,
and he brought him wine and he drank. 21 His father Isaac told him,
"Come close, my son, and kiss me." He came close and kissed him.
22 He smelled the smell of his clothes, and he blessed him and said,
"Look, the smell of my son is like the smell of a full field that the Lord
has blessed. 23 May the Lord give you dew from heaven and dew from
the earth, with an abundance of grain and oil. May nations serve you,
and may peoples bow down before you. 24 Rule over your brothers,
and may your mother's sons bow down to you. May all the blessings
that the Lord has given to me and to my father Abraham be yours and
your descendants' forever. A curse on anyone who curses you, and a
blessing on anyone who blesses you." 25 As soon as Isaac had finished
blessing his son Jacob, and Jacob had gone out from his father Isaac,
he hid himself, and his brother Esau came in from his hunting. 26 He
also made tasty food and brought it to his father, and said to his father,
"Let my father get up and eat of my game, so that your soul may bless
me." 27 His father Isaac said to him, "Who are you?" and he said to him,
"I am your firstborn, your son Esau; I have done as you commanded
me." 28 Isaac was greatly astonished and said, "Who is the one who
hunted and caught game and brought it to me, and I ate everything
before you came, and blessed him? He will be blessed, and all his
descendants forever." 29 When Esau heard his father Isaac's words, he
cried out with a very loud and bitter cry and said to his father, "Bless
me, me also, father." 30 He said to him, "Your brother came with deceit

and has taken away your blessing." Esau said, "Now I know why his name is Jacob: look, he has supplanted me these two times; he took away my birthright, and now he has taken my blessing."[b] 31 He said, "Have you not kept a blessing for me, father?" Isaac answered Esau, "Look, I have made him your lord, and I have given all his brothers to him as servants, and I have strengthened him with plenty of grain, wine, and oil; and what can I do now for you, my son?" 32 Esau said to his father Isaac, "Is there really just one blessing, father? Bless me too, father!" And Esau raised his voice and wept. 33 Isaac answered and said to him, "Look, your dwelling will be far from the dew of the earth and far from the dew of heaven above. 34 By your sword you will live, and you will serve your brother. When you grow great and shake his yoke from your neck, you will sin a complete sin to death, and your descendants will be rooted out from under heaven."[c] 35 Esau kept menacing Jacob over the blessing his father had given him. He said to himself, "Let the days of mourning for my father come soon, so that I can kill my brother Jacob."

Notes

- a (26:18) "Dispensation from heaven" excuses the deception: as with Jacob's deceit in Genesis, the book makes God the author of it.
- b (26:30) Jacob means "he grasps the heel" and so "he supplants" (Gen 27:36).
- c (26:34) This line departs from Genesis 27:40, which says only that Esau will break the yoke. Here breaking it is a sin that destroys Edom, which fits the second-century BC hostility to Edom.

Chapter 27

Jacob Sent to Mesopotamia; the Dream at Bethel

1 Esau's words were told to Rebecca in a dream, and Rebecca sent and called her younger son Jacob and said to him, 2 "Look, your brother Esau will take revenge on you and kill you. 3 So now, my son, obey my voice, and get up and flee to my brother Laban in Haran, and stay with him a few days until your brother's anger turns away and he lets go of his anger against you and forgets everything you have done; then I will send and bring you back from there." 4 Jacob said, "I am not afraid; if he wants to kill me, I will kill him." 5 But she said to him, "Let me not lose both my sons in one day." 6 Jacob said to his mother

Rebecca, “You know my father is old and cannot see, because his eyes are dim. If I leave him, it will seem wrong to him, for I would be going away from you, and my father will be angry and curse me. I will not go. When he sends me himself, then I will.”[a] 7 Rebecca said to Jacob, “I will go in and talk with him, and he will send you off.” 8 Rebecca went in and said to Isaac, “I am weary of my life because of the two daughters of Heth whom Esau has taken as wives; and if Jacob takes a wife from among the daughters of the land such as these, what is the point of my living any longer? For the daughters of Canaan are evil.” 9 Isaac called Jacob and blessed him, and warned him, and said to him, 10 “Do not take a wife from any of the daughters of Canaan; get up and go to Mesopotamia, to the house of Bethuel, your mother’s father, and take a wife from there from the daughters of Laban, your mother’s brother. 11 May God Almighty bless you and increase and multiply you, so that you become a company of nations, and give you the blessings of my father Abraham, to you and your descendants after you, so that you may inherit the land of your wanderings and all the land God gave to Abraham. Go, my son, in peace.” 12 Isaac sent Jacob away, and he went to Mesopotamia, to Laban, son of Bethuel the Syrian, brother of Rebecca, Jacob’s mother. 13 After Jacob had set out for Mesopotamia, Rebecca’s spirit grieved for her son, and she wept. 14 Isaac said to Rebecca, “My sister, do not weep because of my son Jacob; for he goes in peace and will return in peace.[b] 15 The Most High God will keep him from all evil and will be with him, for he will not abandon him all his days. 16 For I know that his ways will prosper in all things wherever he goes, until he returns to us in peace and we see him in peace. 17 Do not fear for him, my sister. He walks a straight road, a man of integrity and faithfulness; he will not be lost. Do not cry.” 18 Isaac comforted Rebecca over her son Jacob and blessed him. 19 In the first year of the second week of the forty-fourth jubilee, Jacob left the Well of the Oath for Haran. On the first day of the first month of that week he reached Luz in the hills, which is Bethel. He arrived there in the evening, left the road toward the west that night, and slept there, since the sun had gone down.[c] 20 He took one of the stones of that place and laid it under the tree at his head,

and he was traveling alone, and he slept. 21 That night he dreamed,
and a ladder was set up on the earth, and its top reached to heaven,
and the angels of the Lord went up and down on it, and the Lord
stood on it. 22 He spoke to Jacob and said, "I am the Lord, God of your
father Abraham and God of Isaac; the land you are sleeping on I will
give to you and your descendants after you. 23 Your descendants will
be like the dust of the earth, and you will spread to the west and east,
north and south, and in you and your descendants all the families of
the nations will be blessed. 24 Look, I will be with you, and will keep
you wherever you go, and I will bring you back to this land in peace;
for I will not leave you until I do everything I told you." 25 Jacob woke
from his sleep and said, "This place is really the house of the Lord,
and I never knew." Afraid, he said, "This place is awe-inspiring. It is
none other than God's house, and this is the gate of heaven." 26 Early
in the morning Jacob rose, took the stone that had been under his
head, stood it up as a marker, and poured oil over its top. He named
the place Bethel; its earlier name was Luz. 27 Jacob made a vow to the
Lord: "If the Lord stays with me and protects me on this journey, and
provides food for me to eat and clothing to wear, and I make it back
to my father's house safely, the Lord will be my God. This stone that
I have set up as a pillar to mark this place will be the Lord's house.
Of everything you give me, my God, I will give you a tenth."

Notes

- a (27:6) The author wants to clear Jacob of leaving his aged father.
- b (27:14) "Sister" as an affectionate name for a wife is found in Tobit 5:20 and Song of Songs 4:9. Here it also defends Isaac's calling Rebecca his sister at Gerar.
- c (27:19) The first day of the first month is about March 22, a Wednesday. The year is 2115 from creation in Charles's count. Luz is the old name for Bethel.

Chapter 28

Jacob's Marriages and the Birth of His Children

1 He went on his journey and came to the land of the east, to Laban,
Rebecca's brother, and stayed with him, and served him for his
daughter Rachel for one week of years.[a] 2 In the first year of the third
week he said to him, "Give me my wife, for whom I have served you
seven years," and Laban said to Jacob, "I will give you your wife." 3

Laban made a feast and took his elder daughter Leah and gave her to
Jacob as a wife, and gave her his maid Zilpah as her maid; and Jacob
did not know, for he thought she was Rachel. 4 He went in to her,
and it was Leah; and Jacob was angry with Laban and said to him,
"Why have you done this to me? Did I not serve you for Rachel and
not for Leah? Why have you wronged me? Take your daughter and I
will go, for you have done evil to me." 5 For Jacob loved Rachel more
than Leah, because Leah's eyes were weak, but her figure was very
handsome; but Rachel had beautiful eyes and a beautiful and very
handsome figure. 6 Laban said to Jacob, "It is not done this way in our
country, to give the younger before the elder." And it is not right to
do this; for it is ordained and written on the heavenly tablets that no
one should give his younger daughter before the elder; the elder is
given first and the younger after her; and the man who does this, they
record guilt against him in heaven, and no one who does this is right-
eous, for this deed is evil before the Lord.[b] 7 Command the children of
Israel not to do this: let them not take or give the younger before they
have given the elder, for it is very wicked. 8 Laban said to Jacob, "Let
the seven days of the feast for this one pass, and I will give you Rachel,
so that you will serve me another seven years, and pasture my sheep
as you did in the former week." 9 On the day when the seven days of
Leah's feast had passed, Laban gave Rachel to Jacob, so that he would
serve him another seven years, and he gave Rachel Bilhah, the sister
of Zilpah, as a maid.[c] 10 He served another seven years for Rachel, for
Leah had been given to him for nothing. 11 The Lord opened Leah's
womb. She conceived and bore Jacob a son, whom he named Reuben,
on the fourteenth of the ninth month, in the first year of the third
week.[d] 12 But Rachel's womb was closed, for the Lord saw that Leah
was hated and Rachel loved. 13 Again Jacob went in to Leah, and she
conceived and bore Jacob a second son, and he named him Simeon,
on the twenty-first of the tenth month, in the third year of this week.[e]
14 Again Jacob went in to Leah, and she conceived and bore a third son,
and he named him Levi, on the new moon of the first month, in the
sixth year of this week.[f] 15 Jacob slept with her again. She conceived
and bore a fourth son, whom he named Judah, on the fifteenth of

the third month, in the first year of the fourth week.[g] 16 Rachel was
jealous of Leah because of all this, since she had no children. She said
to Jacob, “Give me children.” Jacob replied, “Have I kept the fruit of
the womb from you? Have I left you?” 17 When Rachel saw that Leah
had borne Jacob four sons, Reuben, Simeon, Levi, and Judah, she said
to him, “Go in to my maid Bilhah, and she will conceive and bear
a son for me.” 18 She gave him her maid Bilhah as a wife. He went
in to her, and she conceived and bore him a son, and he named him
Dan, on the ninth of the sixth month, in the sixth year of the third
week.[h] 19 Jacob slept with Bilhah a second time. She conceived and
bore Jacob another son, whom Rachel named Naphtali, on the fifth of
the seventh month, in the second year of the fourth week.[i] 20 When
Leah realized she had stopped bearing children, she grew envious of
Rachel and gave her own servant Zilpah to Jacob as a wife. Zilpah
conceived and bore a son, whom Leah named Gad, on the twelfth of
the eighth month, in the third year of the fourth week.[j] 21 He went in
to her again, and she conceived and bore him a second son, and Leah
named him Asher, on the second of the eleventh month, in the fifth
year of the fourth week.[k] 22 Jacob slept with Leah, who conceived and
gave birth to a son, Issachar, on the fourth day of the fifth month in
the fourth year of the fourth week; she handed him over to a wet-
nurse.[l] 23 Jacob went in again to her, and she conceived and bore two
children, a son and a daughter, and she named the son Zebulun and
the daughter Dinah, on the seventh of the seventh month, in the sixth
year of the fourth week.[m] 24 The Lord was gracious to Rachel and
opened her womb, and she conceived and bore a son, and she named
him Joseph, on the new moon of the fourth month, in the sixth year of
this fourth week.[n] 25 In the days when Joseph was born, Jacob said to
Laban, “Give me my wives and sons, and let me go to my father Isaac
and build myself a house; for I have completed the years I served you
for your two daughters, and I will go to my father’s house.” 26 Laban
said to Jacob, “Stay with me for your wages, and pasture my flock
for me again, and take your wages.” 27 They agreed with each other
that he would give him as his wages the lambs and kids born black,
spotted, and white; these were to be his wages. 28 All the sheep bore

spotted, speckled, and black young, variously marked, and they bore again lambs like themselves, and all that were spotted were Jacob's and those not spotted were Laban's. [29] Jacob's possessions multiplied greatly, and he had cattle, sheep, donkeys, camels, menservants, and maidservants. [30] Laban and his sons envied Jacob, and Laban took his sheep back from him, and watched him with evil intent.

Notes

- a (28:1) Seven years.
- b (28:6) This verse is the angel's comment. The rule is not known elsewhere in Jewish tradition.
- c (28:9) The Law forbids marrying two living sisters (Lev 18:18). Bilhah and Zilpah are sisters here and in the Testament of Naphtali 1; later Jewish tradition makes them Laban's daughters.
- d (28:11) Reuben means "See, a son." The ninth month, day 14, falls about December 2. The year is 2122 from creation in Charles's count.
- e (28:13) Tenth month, day 21: about January 9. Simeon means "hearing."
- f (28:14) First day of the first month: about March 22, a Wednesday. Levi means "joined."
- g (28:15) Third month, day 15: about early June, the Feast of Weeks. Judah means "praise." The year number in the manuscripts is uncertain.
- h (28:18) Sixth month, day 9: about August 28. Dan means "he judged." The year number is uncertain in the manuscripts.
- i (28:19) Seventh month, day 5: about September 24. Naphtali means "my wrestling."
- j (28:20) Eighth month, day 12: about October 31. Gad means "fortune."
- k (28:21) Eleventh month, day 2: about January 20. Asher means "happy."
- l (28:22) Fifth month, day 4: about July 24. Issachar means "wages." The order of births is disputed in the manuscripts.
- m (28:23) Seventh month, day 7: about September 26.
- n (28:24) First day of the fourth month: about June 21. The year is 2134 from creation in Charles's count. Joseph means "may he add." The twelve sons follow the order of Genesis 29–35: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Issachar, Zebulun, Joseph, Benjamin.

Chapter 29

Jacob's Flight and Covenant with Laban

[1] When Rachel had borne Joseph, Laban went to shear his sheep, for they were a three days' journey from him. [2] Jacob saw that Laban was going to shear his sheep, and he called Leah and Rachel and

spoke kindly to them, that they should come with him to the land of Canaan. 3 For he told them how he had seen everything in a dream, everything that God had said to him about returning to his father's house, and they said, "We will go with you to every place where you go." 4 Jacob blessed the God of his father Isaac and the God of his grandfather Abraham. He rose, seated his wives and children on camels, gathered all his goods, crossed the river, and entered Gilead. He concealed his plan from Laban and told him nothing. 5 In the seventh year of the fourth week, on the twenty-first of the first month, Jacob set out toward Gilead. Laban chased after him and caught up with him in the hill country of Gilead, on the thirteenth of the third month.[a] 6 The Lord did not let him harm Jacob, for he appeared to him in a dream by night. And Laban spoke to Jacob. 7 On the fifteenth of those days Jacob made a feast for Laban and all who came with him, and Jacob swore to Laban that day, and Laban also to Jacob, that neither would cross the mountain of Gilead to the other with evil purpose.[b] 8 He made a heap there as a witness; for this reason the name of that place is called "The Heap of Witness," after this heap.[c] 9 Before that, however, Gilead was known as the land of the Rephaim, since the Rephaim were born there: giants ten cubits tall, or nine, or eight, down to seven.[d] 10 Their territory stretched from the land of the Ammonites to Mount Hermon, and the seats of their kingdom were Karnaim, Ashtaroth, Edrei, Misur, and Beon.[e] 11 The Lord wiped them out for the wickedness of their deeds, for they were thoroughly vicious. The Amorites, wicked and sinful, settled in their place, and today no nation has filled up its sins to the same extent; none of them has a long life on the earth anymore. 12 Jacob sent Laban away, and he went to Mesopotamia, the land of the east, and Jacob returned to the land of Gilead. 13 He crossed the Jabbok in the ninth month, on the eleventh of it. On that day his brother Esau came to him, and he was reconciled to him, and Esau left him for the land of Seir, but Jacob lived in tents.[f] 14 In the first year of the fifth week in this jubilee he crossed the Jordan and lived beyond the Jordan, and he pastured his sheep from the Sea of the Heap to Beth-shan, to Dothan, and to the forest of Akrabbim.[g] 15 He sent to his father Isaac from all

his goods clothing, food, meat, drink, milk, butter, cheese, and some dates of the valley, [16] and also to his mother Rebecca four times a year, at the turning points of the months, between plowing and harvest, between late summer and the rains, and between winter and spring, at Abraham's tower.[h] [17] Isaac had come back from Beer-sheba, the Well of the Oath, and gone up to his father Abraham's tower, where he was living by himself, away from Esau his son. [18] For in the days when Jacob went to Mesopotamia, Esau took as a wife Mahalath, the daughter of Ishmael, and he gathered all his father's flocks and his wives and went up and lived on Mount Seir, and left his father Isaac alone at the Well of the Oath. [19] Isaac went up from the Well of the Oath and lived in the tower of his father Abraham in the mountains of Hebron. [20] Jacob sent there everything he used to send his father and mother from time to time, whatever they needed. They blessed Jacob with their whole heart and soul.

Notes

- a (29:5) First month, day 21: about April 11. Third month, day 13: about June 2.
- b (29:7) The fifteenth of the third month, the Feast of Weeks, about June 4.
- c (29:8) Gilead, in Hebrew Galeed, means "heap of witness" (Gen 31:47).
- d (29:9) Ten cubits is about 15 feet (4.5 m); seven cubits about 10½ feet (3.2 m); the cubit is taken as 18 inches. Compare Gen 14:5; Deut 3:11.
- e (29:10) These places were scenes of Judas Maccabeus's victories (1 Macc 5), which may be why they are named.
- f (29:13) Ninth month, day 11: about November 29.
- g (29:14) Year 2136 from creation in Charles's count. The text of the first place name is damaged; a Latin copy has "from the Salt Sea."
- h (29:16) The four times match the four quarters of the 364-day year, each ending with a short day, the "days of remembrance" at the turn of the seasons.

Chapter 30

Dinah, the Shechemites, and the Choice of Levi

[1] In the first year of the sixth week he went up to Salem, east of Shechem, in peace, in the fourth month.[a] [2] They took Dinah, Jacob's daughter, into the house of Shechem, the son of Hamor the Hivite, ruler of the region. He raped and defiled her. She was a young girl of twelve. [3] He begged his father and her brothers to give her to him as a wife. Jacob and his sons were angry at the men of Shechem, for

they had defiled their sister Dinah, and they spoke to them with evil intent and dealt deceitfully with them and tricked them.[b] 4 Simeon and Levi came unexpectedly to Shechem and carried out judgment on all the men of Shechem, and killed all the men they found in it and left not one remaining; they killed them all in torment, because they had dishonored their sister Dinah. 5 Never again must it happen, from this day on, that a daughter of Israel is violated. Judgment has been decreed in heaven against such people: that every Shechemite man be put to the sword, because they committed an outrage in Israel. 6 The Lord delivered them into the hands of the sons of Jacob to wipe them out with the sword and carry out judgment on them, so that it would not be done again in Israel that a virgin of Israel is defiled. 7 If there is anyone in Israel who wants to give his daughter or his sister to a man of the descendants of the Gentiles, he will surely die, and they will stone him; for he has done a shameful thing in Israel; and they will burn the woman with fire, because she has dishonored the name of her father's house, and she will be rooted out of Israel.[c] 8 Let no adulteress and no uncleanness be found in Israel through all the days of the generations of the earth; for Israel is holy to the Lord, and every man who has defiled it will surely die; they will stone him. 9 For so it has been ordained and written on the heavenly tablets about all the descendants of Israel: whoever defiles it will surely die, and will be stoned. 10 To this law there is no limit of days, and no remission, and no atonement; but the man who has defiled his daughter will be rooted out from all Israel, because he has given some of his seed to Moloch and acted impiously, defiling it.[d] 11 You, Moses, command the children of Israel and warn them not to give their daughters to the Gentiles, and not to take any of the Gentiles' daughters for their sons, for this is abominable before the Lord. 12 For this reason I have written for you in the words of the Law all the deeds of the Shechemites against Dinah, and how Jacob's sons said, "We will not give our daughter to a man who is uncircumcised, for that would be a disgrace to us." 13 It is a shame for Israel, both for those who give and for those who take foreign women, for this is defiling and loathsome to Israel. 14 Israel will not be free of this uncleanness if it has a wife

from the daughters of the Gentiles, or has given any of its daughters to a man of any of the Gentiles. 15 Plague will follow plague and curse follow curse, and every kind of judgment will fall on anyone who does this, or who looks away from people practicing such impurity, or from those who pollute the Lord's sanctuary or dishonor his holy name. Then the entire nation will be judged together for this one man's impurity and profanation. 16 There will be no favoritism and no partiality, and he will not accept from his hands fruits, offerings, burnt offerings, fat, or the fragrance of a pleasing aroma, so as to accept it; and so it will be with every man or woman in Israel who defiles the sanctuary. 17 That is why I ordered you: "Give this witness to Israel. Look at what became of the Shechemites and their sons: two of Jacob's sons handed them over to death, and killed them in torment. It was credited to the two as justice, and recorded in their favor as justice. 18 The descendants of Levi were chosen for the priesthood and to be Levites, to serve before the Lord continually, as we do, and so that Levi and his sons may be blessed forever; for he was zealous to carry out righteousness, judgment, and vengeance on all who rose up against Israel.[e] 19 So they record on the heavenly tablets blessing and righteousness in his favor before the God of all. 20 We recall the man's justice, shown throughout his life in every season. For a thousand generations they will keep the record, and it will pass to him and to his descendants after him. He is entered on the heavenly tablets as a friend and a just man. 21 All this account I have written for you, and have commanded you to tell the children of Israel that they should not sin, nor transgress the ordinances, nor break the covenant that has been ordained for them, but should fulfill it and be recorded as friends. 22 But if they transgress and practice uncleanness in any way, they will be recorded on the heavenly tablets as adversaries, and they will be destroyed out of the book of life, and they will be recorded in the book of those who will be destroyed and rooted out of the earth.[f] 23 On the day when the sons of Jacob killed Shechem, a writing was recorded in their favor in heaven, that they had executed righteousness, uprightness, and vengeance on the sinners, and it was written for a blessing. 24 They brought their sister

Dinah out of Shechem's house, and they took captive everything in Shechem, their sheep, cattle, donkeys, all their wealth, and all their flocks, and brought them all to their father Jacob. 25 He reproached them because they had put the city to the sword, for he feared those who lived in the land, the Canaanites and the Perizzites. 26 The dread of the Lord was on all the cities around Shechem, and they did not rise to pursue the sons of Jacob, for terror had fallen on them.

Notes

- a (30:1) Charles dates this to 2143 from creation. "Salem" and "in peace" are the same Hebrew word, shalem/shalom, and the text joins both readings (Gen 33:18). The fourth month runs from about June 21.
- b (30:3) The book leaves out the circumcision of the Shechemites, for it approves of what Simeon and Levi did and praises it. Genesis 49:5–7 condemns their act. The attitude here fits the strong hostility to Shechem (the Samaritans) in the author's time.
- c (30:7) This passage is a fierce attack on marriage with outsiders. Leviticus 21:9 prescribes burning only for a priest's daughter who becomes a prostitute.
- d (30:10) Compare Lev 18:21 and 20:2–5, where giving offspring to Moloch is forbidden. Here marrying a daughter to a Gentile is made the same as that sin.
- e (30:18) Another reason for Levi's choice is given in 32:3. Compare Testament of Levi 4–6.
- f (30:22) The "book of life" (Ex 32:32; Ps 69:28) first meant the register of the living people of God. Later it means eternal life (Rev 3:5; 1 Enoch 47:3).

Chapter 31

Jacob at Bethel and Hebron; Isaac Blesses Levi and Judah

1 On the new moon of the month Jacob spoke to all the people of his house, saying, "Purify yourselves and change your clothes, and let us get up and go to Bethel, where I made a vow to him on the day I fled from my brother Esau, because he has been with me and brought me into this land in peace; and put away the foreign gods that are among you." 2 They gave up the foreign gods and what was in their ears and on their necks, and Rachel gave Jacob all the idols she had stolen from her brother Laban. He burned them and broke them to pieces and destroyed them, and hid them under an oak in the land of Shechem. 3 He went up to Bethel on the new moon of the seventh month. He built an altar at the place where he had slept, and set up a pillar there, and sent word to his father Isaac to come to him for his sacrifice,

and to his mother Rebecca.[a] 4 Isaac said, “Let my son Jacob come, and
let me see him before I die.” 5 Jacob went to his father Isaac and his
mother Rebecca, to the house of his father Abraham, and he took
two of his sons with him, Levi and Judah, and he came to his father
Isaac and his mother Rebecca.[b] 6 Rebecca came out of the tower to its
entrance to kiss and hug Jacob. When she heard, “Your son Jacob is
here,” her spirit had come back to life, and she kissed him. 7 She looked
at his two sons and knew them, and she said, “Are these your sons,
my son?” She hugged and kissed them and blessed them: “Through
you Abraham’s descendants will become renowned, and you will be
a blessing on the earth.” 8 Jacob went in to his father Isaac, to the room
where he lay, and his two sons were with him, and he took his father’s
hand and bent down and kissed him, and Isaac clung to the neck of
his son Jacob and wept on his neck. 9 The dimness lifted from Isaac’s
eyes and he saw Jacob’s two sons, Levi and Judah. He said, “Are these
your sons, my son? They look just like you.” 10 Jacob told him that they
were truly his sons; “and you have truly seen that they are truly my
sons.” 11 They stepped up to him, and he turned, kissed them, and held
them both in one embrace. 12 The spirit of prophecy fell on his lips. He
took Levi’s right hand and Judah’s left. 13 He turned to Levi first, and
began to bless him first, and said to him, “May the God of all, the very
Lord of all the ages, bless you and your children through all the ages.[c]
14 May the Lord give you and your offspring great honor and splendor,
and choose you and your offspring out of all humanity to come near
him and serve in his sanctuary, like the angels of the presence and
the holy ones. As they are, so may the descendants of your sons be:
glorious, great, and holy, and may he make them great for all ages.[d]
15 They will be rulers, judges, and leaders over all the offspring of
Jacob’s sons. They will speak the Lord’s word with justice and decide
all his cases justly. They will make my ways known to Jacob and my
paths to Israel. The Lord’s blessing will be placed in their mouths, to
bless all the offspring of the beloved.[e] 16 Your mother named you Levi,
and she named you rightly: you will be joined to the Lord and be a
companion to all Jacob’s sons. Let his table be yours; eat from it, you
and your sons. May your table be full in every generation, and your

food never run short through all the ages.[f] 17 Let all who hate you fall
down before you, let all your adversaries be rooted out and perish;
blessed be the one who blesses you, and cursed be every nation that
curses you." 18 To Judah he said, "May the Lord give you strength and
power to tread down all who hate you. You will be a prince, you and
one of your sons, over the sons of Jacob; may your name and your
sons' name go out and cross every land and region. Then the Gentiles
will fear before your face, and all the nations will quake, and all the
peoples will tremble. 19 In you will be the help of Jacob, and in you
will be found the salvation of Israel. 20 When you sit on the throne
of the honor of your righteousness, there will be great peace for all
the descendants of the sons of the beloved; blessed be the one who
blesses you, and all who hate you, afflict you, and curse you will be
rooted out and destroyed from the earth and be accursed." 21 Turning,
he kissed him again and embraced him, and rejoiced greatly because
he had seen the sons of his son Jacob in very truth. 22 He went out from
between his feet and fell down and bowed to him. And he blessed
them. And Jacob rested there with his father Isaac that night, and they
ate and drank with joy. 23 He made the two sons of Jacob sleep, one at
his right hand and the other at his left, and it was counted to him as
righteousness. 24 Through that night Jacob told his father everything:
the great kindness the Lord had shown him, how he had made all
his undertakings succeed, and guarded him from every harm. 25 Isaac
blessed the God of his father Abraham, who had not withdrawn his
mercy and righteousness from the sons of his servant Isaac. 26 In the
morning Jacob told his father Isaac the vow he had made to the Lord,
and the vision he had seen, and that he had built an altar, and that
everything was ready for the sacrifice to be made before the Lord as
he had vowed, and that he had come to set him on a donkey. 27 Isaac
said to his son Jacob, "I cannot go with you, for I am old and cannot
bear the journey. Go, my son, in peace, for I am a hundred and sixty-
five years old this day; I can no longer travel. Set your mother on a
donkey and let her go with you.[g] 28 I know, my son, that you have
come on my account, and may this day be blessed on which you saw
me alive and I also saw you, my son. 29 May you prosper and fulfill

the vow you made; do not put off your vow, for you will be called to account for it; so make haste to carry it out, and may he who made all things be pleased, to whom you made the vow." 30 He said to Rebecca, "Go with your son Jacob," and Rebecca went with her son Jacob, and Deborah with her, and they came to Bethel. 31 Jacob remembered the prayer with which his father had blessed him and his sons Levi and Judah. He was glad and blessed the God of his fathers, Abraham and Isaac. 32 He said, "Now I know that I and my sons have an everlasting hope before the God of all." So this was decreed for the two of them, and the way Isaac blessed them is written on the heavenly tablets as their lasting witness.

Notes

- a (31:3) The new moon of the seventh month is the first day of the seventh month, about September 20, a Wednesday.
- b (31:5) Hebron. Rabbinic tradition does not mention this last meeting of Jacob and Isaac.
- c (31:13) Levi is given first place. Compare Testament of Levi 9.
- d (31:14) Levi's line is to serve in the sanctuary as the two highest orders of angels serve in heaven (see 2:2, 18).
- e (31:15) Priests who also rule: the Maccabean priest-princes held both roles. The beloved is Abraham.
- f (31:16) Levi means "joined" (Gen 29:34).
- g (31:27) Isaac was 60 when Jacob was born (Gen 25:26) and would be 165 at the time given here, which is about 105 years old when Jacob was 45; the book's own count is meant.

Chapter 32

Levi's Dream, the Tithes, and Israel's Name

1 He stayed that night at Bethel, and Levi dreamed that they had ordained him and made him priest of the Most High God, him and his sons forever; and he woke from his sleep and blessed the Lord.[a] 2 Jacob got up early in the morning on the fourteenth of this month and gave a tithe of everything that came with him, of both people and cattle, of gold and every vessel and garment; yes, he gave tithes of everything.[b] 3 In those days Rachel became pregnant with her son Benjamin. Jacob counted his sons from him upward, and Levi fell to the portion of the Lord, and his father clothed him in the garments

of the priesthood and filled his hands.[c] 4 On the fifteenth of this
month he brought fourteen bulls from the herd, twenty-eight rams,
forty-nine sheep, seven lambs, and twenty-one young goats to the
altar as a burnt offering, a sweet aroma pleasing to God.[d] 5 This was
his offering, because of the vow he had made that he would give
a tenth, with their grain offerings and drink offerings. 6 When the
fire had consumed it, he burned incense on the fire over it, and for
a thank offering two oxen, four rams, four sheep, four male goats,
two yearling sheep, and two kids of the goats; and so he did daily for
seven days. 7 He and all his sons and his men ate this with joy there
for seven days, blessing and thanking the Lord, who had delivered
him from all his trouble and given him his vow. 8 He tithed all the
clean animals and made a burnt sacrifice, but the unclean animals he
did not give to his son Levi; and he gave him all the souls of the men.[e]
9 Levi served as priest at Bethel before his father Jacob, in preference
to his ten brothers, and he was priest there, and Jacob fulfilled his
vow; so he tithed again the tithe to the Lord and made it holy, and it
became holy to him. 10 For this reason it is ordained on the heavenly
tablets as a law that the tithe be tithed again, to eat before the Lord
from year to year in the place chosen for his name to dwell, and to
this law there is no limit of days forever.[f] 11 This ordinance is written
so that it may be fulfilled from year to year, eating the second tithe
before the Lord in the place chosen, and nothing is to remain over
from it from this year to the year following. 12 For in its own year
the seed is to be eaten until the days of the gathering of the year's
seed, and the wine until the days of the wine, and the oil until the
days of its season. 13 All that is left over and has become old is to be
treated as polluted; let it be burned with fire, for it is unclean. 14 So
let them eat it together in the sanctuary, and not let it become old.
15 All the tithes of the cattle and sheep will be holy to the Lord, and
will belong to his priests, who will eat them before him from year
to year; for so it is ordained and engraved regarding the tithe on the
heavenly tablets. 16 On the following night, the twenty-second day of
this month, Jacob decided to build that place and surround the court
with a wall, and to make it holy forever, for himself and his children

after him.[g] 17 The Lord appeared to him by night and blessed him
and said to him, "Your name will not be called Jacob, but they will
name you Israel." 18 He said to him again, "I am the Lord, who created
heaven and earth, and I will increase you and multiply you greatly,
and kings will come from you, and they will judge everywhere the
foot of human beings has trodden. 19 I will give your descendants all
the earth that is under heaven, and they will judge all the nations
as they desire, and after that they will take possession of the whole
earth and inherit it forever."[h] 20 He finished speaking with him, and
he went up from him, and Jacob watched until he had ascended into
heaven. 21 He saw in a vision of the night, and an angel came down
from heaven with seven tablets in his hands, and gave them to Jacob,
and he read them and knew everything written in them that would
happen to him and his sons through all the ages.[i] 22 He showed him
all that was written on the tablets, and said to him, "Do not build this
place, and do not make it an eternal sanctuary, and do not live here,
for this is not the place. Go to the house of your father Abraham and
live with your father Isaac until the day of your father's death.[j] 23 For
in Egypt you will die in peace, and in this land you will be buried with
honor in the tomb of your fathers, with Abraham and Isaac. 24 Do not
be afraid, for what you have seen and read will all be so; and write
down everything as you have seen and read it." 25 Jacob said, "Lord,
how can I remember everything I have read and seen?" and he said
to him, "I will bring everything to your remembrance."[k] 26 He went up
from him, and Jacob woke from his sleep and remembered everything
he had read and seen, and he wrote down all the words he had read
and seen. 27 He celebrated there yet another day, and sacrificed on it
according to everything he had sacrificed on the former days, and he
named it "Addition," because this day was added, and the former days
he called "The Feast."[l] 28 So the right way was shown to him, and it
stands written on the heavenly tablets; and it was revealed to him that
he should keep it, adding this day to the seven days of the feast. 29 Its
name was called "Addition," because it was recorded among the feast
days in the number of the days of the year.[m] 30 That night, the twenty-
third of the month, Deborah, Rebecca's nurse, died. She was buried

beneath the town under the river oak. Jacob called the spot "The River of Deborah" and the oak "The Oak of Deborah's Mourning."[n] 31 Rebecca went back to her home, to his father Isaac. Jacob sent along with her rams, sheep, and he-goats so she could prepare for his father the kind of meal he liked. 32 He went after his mother until he came to the land of Kabratan, and he lived there.[o] 33 Rachel gave birth to a son during the night and called him "Son of my sorrow," because the birth had caused her such pain. But his father named him Benjamin, on the eleventh of the eighth month, in the first year of the sixth week of this jubilee.[p] 34 Rachel died there and was buried in the land of Ephrath, which is Bethlehem, and Jacob built a pillar on Rachel's grave, on the road above her grave.

Notes

- a (32:1) Testament of Levi 8 puts Levi's vision of seven men in white at Bethel. "Priest of the Most High God" is also Melchizedek's title (Gen 14:18), later taken up by the Maccabean priest-kings; see also Ps 110:4.
- b (32:2) The fourteenth of the seventh month: about October 3.
- c (32:3) Counting backward from Benjamin (1) to Levi (10th), Levi is the tenth and so the tithe (Lev 27:32). "Filled his hands" is the technical term for ordination as a priest (Ex 29:9).
- d (32:4) The fifteenth of the seventh month, about October 4, is the Feast of Tabernacles. The numbers of animals do not match Num 29:12–40.
- e (32:8) That is, the people and servants of his household who were counted in the tithe, as Testament of Levi 9 says.
- f (32:10) The second tithe: Deut 14:23.
- g (32:16) The twenty-second of the seventh month: about October 11, the eighth day after the start of Tabernacles.
- h (32:19) Here the promise covers the whole inhabited earth, not only the land of Canaan as in Gen 35:12.
- i (32:21) Compare 4 Ezra 14:24.
- j (32:22) The Bethel sanctuary is not to be the one central shrine. Compare 45:4.
- k (32:25) Compare 4 Ezra 14:40 and John 14:26.
- l (32:27) This is the eighth day of Tabernacles (Lev 23:36). The Hebrew name is aseret, "assembly" or "holding back." The Ethiopic text is corrupt here; Charles suggests "keeping back," because he was kept back on that day.
- m (32:29) The text of this verse is very damaged. The sense is that the eighth day is counted among the festal days of the year.
- n (32:30) The twenty-third of the seventh month: about October 12. Compare Gen 35:8.

- o (32:32) This place name comes from a misunderstanding of Hebrew kibrath ha'arets, "some distance," in Gen 35:16.
- p (32:33) Eighth month, day 11: about October 30. The year is 2143 from creation in Charles's count. Benjamin means "son of the right hand" or "of the south"; Benoni, "son of my sorrow."

Chapter 33

Reuben and Bilhah; Laws on Incest

1 Jacob went and lived to the south of Magdaladra'ef, and he went to his father Isaac, he and his wife Leah, on the new moon of the tenth month.[a] 2 Reuben saw Bilhah, Rachel's maid, his father's concubine, bathing in water in a secret place, and he desired her. 3 He hid himself at night, and entered Bilhah's house, and found her sleeping alone on a bed in her house. 4 He lay with her, and she woke and saw that Reuben was lying with her in the bed, and she pulled the edge of her covering and seized him, and cried out, and discovered that it was Reuben. 5 She was ashamed because of him, and released her hand from him, and he fled. 6 She lamented greatly over this thing and did not tell anyone. 7 When Jacob returned and sought her, she said to him, "I am not clean for you, for I have been defiled as far as you are concerned; for Reuben has defiled me and lain with me in the night, and I was asleep and did not know until he uncovered my skirt and slept with me." 8 Jacob was very angry with Reuben because he had lain with Bilhah, because he had uncovered his father's skirt. 9 Jacob did not go near her again because Reuben had defiled her. And any man who uncovers his father's skirt does a very wicked deed, for he is abominable before the Lord. 10 For this reason the heavenly tablets contain this written decree: no man may sleep with his father's wife or lift the edge of his father's robe, for that is defiling. Both are certain to die, the man who sleeps with his father's wife and the woman too, because they have polluted the land. 11 There will be nothing unclean before our God in the nation he has chosen for himself as a possession. 12 A second time it is written: "Cursed is the man who lies with his father's wife, for he has exposed his father's shame." And all the Lord's holy ones said, "So be it, so be it." 13 You, Moses, command the children of Israel to keep this word; for it carries the penalty of

death; and it is unclean, and there is no atonement forever to atone for the man who has done this, but he is to be put to death, killed, stoned, and rooted out from the midst of the people of our God. [14] No man in Israel who does this may stay alive even one day on earth, for he is loathsome and impure. [15] Let them not say that Reuben was granted life and forgiveness after he lay with his father's concubine, and she also, though she had a husband, and her husband Jacob, his father, was still alive. [16] For until that time the ordinance, judgment, and law had not been revealed in full for everyone, but in your days it has been revealed as a law of seasons and days, and an everlasting law for the everlasting generations.[b] [17] For this law there is no end of days and no atonement; but both must be rooted out from the midst of the nation; on the day they commit it, they shall kill them. [18] You, Moses, write it down for Israel so that they keep it and act according to these words and do not commit a sin unto death; for the Lord our God is judge, who shows no favoritism and accepts no gifts. [19] Tell them these words of the covenant, so that they hear and keep them and are on their guard concerning them, and are not destroyed and rooted out of the land; for all who commit it on the earth are uncleanness, abomination, contamination, and pollution before our God. [20] There is no greater sin than the fornication they commit on the earth; for Israel is a holy nation to the Lord its God, a nation of inheritance, a priestly and royal nation and his own possession; and no such uncleanness will appear in the midst of the holy nation. [21] In the third year of this sixth week Jacob and all his sons went and lived in the house of Abraham, near his father Isaac and his mother Rebecca.[c] [22] These were the names of Jacob's sons: the firstborn Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun, the sons of Leah; and the sons of Rachel, Joseph and Benjamin; and the sons of Bilhah, Dan and Naphtali; and the sons of Zilpah, Gad and Asher; and Dinah, Leah's daughter, the only daughter of Jacob. [23] They came and bowed to Isaac and Rebecca, and when they saw them they blessed Jacob and all his sons, and Isaac rejoiced greatly, for he saw the sons of his younger son Jacob, and he blessed them.

Notes

- a (33:1) The new moon of the tenth month is the first day of the tenth month, about December 20, a Wednesday. The place name stands for "the tower of Eder of Ephrath" (Gen 35:21).
- b (33:16) Compare Rom 4:15: "where there is no law there is no transgression."
- c (33:21) Year 2145 from creation in Charles's count.

Chapter 34

War with the Amorite Kings; Joseph Sold; the Day of Atonement

1 In the sixth year of this week of this forty-fourth jubilee Jacob sent his sons to pasture their sheep, and his servants with them, in the pastures of Shechem.[a] 2 The seven kings of the Amorites gathered against them to kill them, hiding under the trees, and to take their cattle as plunder.[b] 3 Jacob, Levi, Judah, and Joseph were in the house with their father Isaac, for his spirit was sorrowful and they could not leave him; and Benjamin, the youngest, stayed with his father for that reason. 4 Then came the king of Taphu, the king of Aresa, the king of Seragan, the king of Selo, the king of Ga'as, the king of Bethhoron, the king of Ma'anisakir, and all those who live in these mountains and in the woods in the land of Canaan.[c] 5 They told Jacob, "Look, the Amorite kings have surrounded your sons and plundered their herds." 6 He got up from his house, he and his three sons and all his father's servants and his own servants, and went against them with six thousand men carrying swords. 7 He killed them in the pastures of Shechem, and pursued those who fled, and he killed them with the edge of the sword, and he killed Aresa, Taphu, Seragan, Selo, Ma'anisakir, and Ga'as, and recovered his herds.[d] 8 He prevailed over them and imposed tribute on them, that they should pay him tribute of five fruit products of their land, and he built Robel and Tamnatares.[e] 9 He came back safely and made terms with them, and they were his subjects until the day he and his sons went down into Egypt. 10 In the seventh year of this week he sent Joseph from his house to the region of Shechem to see how his brothers were, and Joseph found them near Dothan. 11 They dealt treacherously with him and made a plot against him to kill him, but changing their minds, they sold him to Ishmaelite merchants, and they brought him down

to Egypt and sold him to Potiphar, Pharaoh's official, the chief of the cooks, priest of the city of Elew.[f] 12 The sons of Jacob killed a kid and dipped Joseph's coat in the blood and sent it to their father Jacob on the tenth of the seventh month.[g] 13 He mourned the whole night, since they had brought him the news at evening. Grief made him feverish over the death, and he said, "A wild animal has eaten Joseph." Everyone in his household wept and mourned with him throughout that day. 14 His sons and his daughter got up to comfort him, but he refused to be comforted for his son. 15 On that day Bilhah heard that Joseph had perished, and she died mourning him; she was living in Kabratan, and Dinah his daughter also died after Joseph perished. And these three mournings came on Israel in one month. 16 They buried Bilhah opposite Rachel's tomb, and Dinah his daughter they buried there too. 17 He mourned for Joseph one year, and did not stop, for he said, "Let me go down to the grave mourning for my son." 18 For this reason it is ordained for the children of Israel that they should humble themselves on the tenth of the seventh month, the day the news that made Jacob weep for Joseph reached him, and that they should make atonement for themselves on it with a young goat on the tenth of the seventh month, once a year, for their sins; for they had grieved their father's love over his son Joseph.[h] 19 This day has been ordained so that they should grieve on it for their sins, for all their transgressions and all their errors, so that they might cleanse themselves on that day once a year. 20 After Joseph perished, Jacob's sons took wives for themselves. The name of Reuben's wife was Ada; the name of Simeon's wife was Adiba'a, a Canaanite; the name of Levi's wife was Melka, of the daughters of Aram, of the descendants of the sons of Terah; the name of Judah's wife, Betasu'el, a Canaanite; the name of Issachar's wife, Hezaqa; the name of Zebulun's wife, Ni'iman; the name of Dan's wife, 'Egla; the name of Naphtali's wife, Rasu'u, of Mesopotamia; the name of Gad's wife, Maka; the name of Asher's wife, Ijona; the name of Joseph's wife, Asenath the Egyptian; and the name of Benjamin's wife, 'Ijasaka.[i] 21 Simeon repented and took a second wife from Mesopotamia, as his brothers did.

Notes

- a (34:1) Charles dates this to 2148 from creation.
- b (34:2) The war story is told more fully in the Testament of Judah 3–7. It fits Gen 48:22, where Jacob says he took Shechem with sword and bow.
- c (34:4) Taphu is probably Tappuah. Aresa may be Hazor. Selo is Shiloh. Bethhoron was the scene of several Maccabean victories (1 Macc 3:13–24). Several of these places are famous from Maccabean battles, which may be why the author names them.
- d (34:7) Six of the seven kings are killed; so also the Testament of Judah 4.
- e (34:8) Timnath-heres, as in Judg 2:9.
- f (34:11) The Greek calls Potiphar "chief cook" by mistaking the Hebrew ("captain of the guard"). Elew is Heliopolis (On), the Egyptian temple city.
- g (34:12) The tenth of the seventh month: about September 29, a Friday in this calendar.
- h (34:18) This reason for the Day of Atonement (Lev 16) is peculiar to Jubilees. "Humble themselves" means to fast.
- i (34:20) Betasu'el is "daughter of Shua" (Gen 38:2). Compare Testament of Levi 11. These marriages with Canaanites conflict with 30:7–10.

Chapter 35

Rebecca's Last Words and Death

1 In the first year of the first week of the forty-fifth jubilee Rebecca called her son Jacob and commanded him concerning his father and his brother, that he should honor them all the days of his life.[a] 2 Jacob said, "I will do everything as you have commanded me; for this will be honor and greatness to me, and righteousness before the Lord, that I should honor them. 3 You too, mother, know from the time I was born until this day all my deeds and everything in my heart, that I always think good toward everyone. 4 How could I not do this thing you have commanded me, that I should honor my father and my brother? 5 Tell me, mother, what perversity have you seen in me, and I will turn away from it, and mercy will be on me." 6 She answered, "My son, in all my days I have seen nothing twisted in you, only what is right. Still, let me tell you plainly: I am going to die this year and will not outlive it. I saw the day of my death in a dream, and I am not to live past a hundred and fifty-five years. Look, I have used up all the days I was given to live." 7 Jacob laughed at his mother's words, because his mother had told him that she would die; and she was sitting opposite him in full strength, and was not weak; for she

came and went and saw, and her teeth were strong, and no illness had touched her all the days of her life. [8] Jacob said to her, "Blessed am I, mother, if my days come near the days of your life, and my strength stays with me as yours does; and you will not die, for you are joking idly with me about your death." [9] She went in to Isaac and said to him, "I make one request of you: make Esau swear that he will not harm Jacob or pursue him with enmity; for you know Esau's thoughts, that they have been perverse from his youth, and there is no goodness in him; for he wants you dead, to kill him. [10] You know everything he has done from the day his brother Jacob went to Haran until this day: how he has abandoned us with his whole heart and done evil to us; he has taken your flocks for himself and carried off all your possessions from before your face. [11] When we begged and pleaded with him for what was our own, he acted like a man doing us a favor. [12] He is bitter against you because you blessed Jacob, your perfect and upright son; for there is no evil in him, only goodness, and since he came from Haran until this day he has not robbed us of anything, for he brings us everything in its season always, and rejoices with all his heart when we take from his hands, and he blesses us, and has not left us since he came from Haran until this day, and he stays with us continually at home, honoring us." [13] Isaac said to her, "I also know and see what Jacob does, how he honors us wholeheartedly. I used to love Esau more than Jacob because he was the firstborn, but now I love Jacob more, since Esau has done many wicked things and has no justice in him: every one of his ways is wrongdoing and violence. [14] Now my heart is troubled because of all his deeds, and neither he nor his descendants will be saved, for they are those who will be destroyed from the earth and rooted out from under heaven, for he has abandoned the God of Abraham and gone after his wives and after their uncleanness and their error, he and his children. [15] You tell me to make him swear that he will not kill his brother Jacob; even if he swears, he will not keep his oath, and he will do no good but only evil. [16] But if he wants to kill his brother Jacob, he will be given into Jacob's hands, and will not escape from his hands. [17] Do not be afraid for Jacob, for Jacob's guardian is great, powerful, honored, and

praised more than Esau's guardian."[b] 18 Rebecca sent and called Esau,
and he came to her, and she said to him, "I have a request to make
of you, my son, and promise to do it, my son." 19 He said, "I will do
everything you say to me, and I will not refuse your request." 20 She
said to him, "I ask that on the day I die you will take me in and bury
me near Sarah, your father's mother, and that you and Jacob will love
each other, and that neither will want evil against the other, but only
mutual love, and so you will prosper, my sons, and be honored in the
midst of the land, and no enemy will rejoice over you, and you will
be a blessing and a mercy in the eyes of all who love you." 21 He said,
"I will do all you have told me, and I will bury you on the day you
die near Sarah, my father's mother, as you desire that her bones be
near your bones. 22 And my brother Jacob I will love above every other
person, since I have no brother in the whole world except him. There
is no great virtue in my loving him: he is my brother, we were planted
together in your body and came out together from your womb. If I did
not love my brother, whom would I love? 23 I myself beg you to exhort
Jacob concerning me and my sons, for I know that he will surely be
king over me and my sons, for on the day my father blessed him he
made him the higher and me the lower. 24 I swear to you that I will
love him, and not want evil against him all the days of my life, but
only good." And he swore to her about all this matter. 25 She called
Jacob before Esau's eyes and gave him a commandment according to
the words she had spoken to Esau. 26 He said, "I will do what pleases
you; believe me that no evil will come from me or my sons against
Esau, and I will be first in nothing but love." 27 They ate and drank, she
and her sons, that night, and she died that night, three jubilees and
one week and one year old, and her two sons Esau and Jacob buried
her in the double cave near Sarah, their father's mother.[c]

Notes

- a (35:1) Year 2157 from creation in Charles's count.
- b (35:17) "Guardian" here is a guardian angel; compare Matt 18:10; Acts 12:15.
- c (35:27) 3 × 49 + 7 + 1 = 155 years. The double cave is Machpelah.

Chapter 36

Isaac's Last Words and Death; the Death of Leah

1 In the sixth year of this week Isaac summoned his two sons, Esau
and Jacob. When they came he told them, "My sons, I am about to
take the road my fathers took, to the everlasting home where they
are.[a] 2 So bury me near my father Abraham, in the double cave in the
field of Ephron the Hittite, where Abraham bought a tomb to bury
in; in the tomb that I dug for myself, bury me there. 3 I command you,
my sons, to practice righteousness and uprightness on the earth, so
that the Lord may bring on you all that the Lord said he would do
for Abraham and his descendants. 4 Love each other, my sons, the
way a person loves his own life. Let each look for ways to help his
brother, and let them work together in the land, loving one another
as they love themselves. 5 Concerning idols, I command and warn
you to reject them and hate them and not love them, for they are full
of deception for those who worship them and bow down to them. 6
Remember, my sons, the Lord God of your father Abraham, and how
I too worshiped him and served him in righteousness and joy, so that
he might multiply you and increase your descendants like the stars of
heaven, and establish you on the earth as the plant of righteousness
that will not be rooted out through all generations forever. 7 Now I
will make you swear a great oath, for there is no oath greater than
it, by the glorious, honored, great, splendid, wonderful, and mighty
name, which created the heavens and earth and all things together,
that you will fear him and worship him. 8 And that each of you will
love his brother with affection and righteousness, and that neither of
you will want evil against his brother from now on forever, all the
days of your life, so that you may prosper in all your deeds and not
be destroyed. 9 If either of you plots evil against his brother, know
that from now on everyone who plots evil against his brother will
fall into his hand and be rooted out of the land of the living, and his
descendants will be destroyed from under heaven. 10 On the day of
confusion, of cursing, fury, and anger, with blazing, consuming fire,
just as he burned Sodom, so he will burn that man's land and town
and everything he owns. He will be wiped from the book of human

instruction and not entered in the book of life, but in the book marked for destruction. He will depart into an everlasting curse, so that their sentence is renewed forever in hatred, cursing, rage, torment, fury, plagues, and sickness. 11 I say and testify to you, my sons, according to the judgment that will come on the man who wants to injure his brother." 12 He divided all his possessions between the two on that day, and he gave the larger portion to the firstborn, together with the tower and everything around it, and everything Abraham had possessed at the Well of the Oath. 13 He said, "This larger portion I will give to the firstborn." 14 Esau said, "I sold my birthright to Jacob and gave it to him; let it be given to him, and I have nothing to say about it, for it is his." 15 Isaac said, "May a blessing rest on you, my sons, and on your descendants this day, for you have given me rest, and my heart is not pained about the birthright, lest you work wickedness because of it. 16 May the Most High God bless the man who works righteousness, him and his descendants forever." 17 When he had finished instructing and blessing them, they ate and drank together in his presence. He was glad that the two were of one mind. They left him, spent the rest of the day at rest, and went to sleep. 18 That day Isaac lay down on his bed, glad at heart, and fell into the everlasting sleep, dying at a hundred and eighty. He had lived twenty-five weeks of years and five years. His two sons, Esau and Jacob, buried him.[b] 19 Esau went to the land of Edom, to the mountains of Seir, and lived there. 20 Jacob lived in the mountains of Hebron, in the tower of the land of the wanderings of his father Abraham, and he worshiped the Lord with all his heart and according to the visible commands, as he had divided the days of his generations.[c] 21 Leah, his wife, died in the fourth year of the second week of the forty-fifth jubilee. He buried her in the twin cave next to his mother Rebecca, on the left of the tomb of Sarah, his father's mother.[d] 22 All her sons and his sons came to mourn over his wife Leah with him, and to comfort him about her, for he was lamenting her. 23 For he loved her very much after her sister Rachel died; for she was perfect and upright in all her ways and honored Jacob, and all the days she lived with him he did not hear a harsh word from her mouth, for she was gentle, peaceable, upright, and honorable. 24

He remembered all her deeds that she had done during her life, and he lamented her greatly; for he loved her with all his heart and all his soul.

Notes

- a (36:1) Year 2162 from creation in Charles's count. "Eternal house" is the grave; compare Eccl 12:5.
- b (36:18) 25 × 7 + 5 = 180.
- c (36:20) The commands were made visible to Jacob on the seven tablets that the angel showed him (32:21). "Most High God" (verse 16) is a favorite title in this book, in Sirach, Daniel, and 4 Ezra.
- d (36:21) Year 2167 from creation in Charles's count.

Chapter 37

Esau's Sons Make War on Jacob

1 On the day that Isaac, the father of Jacob and Esau, died, the sons of Esau heard that Isaac had given the elder's portion to his younger son Jacob, and they were very angry.[a] 2 They quarreled with their father, saying, "Why has your father given Jacob the elder's portion and passed over you, although you are the elder and Jacob the younger?" 3 He told them, "I traded my birthright to Jacob for a bowl of lentil stew. Then, the day my father sent me out to hunt game and bring him something to eat so he could bless me, Jacob came in with a trick and brought my father food and drink. My father blessed him and made me his subject. 4 Now our father has made us swear, me and him, that we will not plot evil against each other, but will continue in love and peace, each with his brother, and not make our ways corrupt." 5 They said to him, "We will not listen to you to make peace with him; for our strength is greater than his, and we are more powerful than he; we will go against him and kill him and destroy him and his sons. And if you will not go with us, we will do harm to you too. 6 Now listen to us: let us send to Aram, Philistia, Moab, and Ammon, and choose for ourselves chosen men who are eager for battle, and let us go against him and fight him, and exterminate him from the earth before he grows strong."[b] 7 Their father said to them, "Do not go and do not make war with him, or you will fall before him." 8 They said to him, "This too is exactly how you have behaved from your youth

until this day, and you put your neck under his yoke. We will not
listen to these words." 9 They sent to Aram and to Aduram, the friend
of their father, and hired a thousand fighting men with them, chosen
men of war. 10 From Moab and from the Ammonites came a thousand
hired chosen men, and from Philistia a thousand chosen men of war,
and from Edom and the Horites a thousand chosen fighting men, and
from the Kittim mighty men of war. 11 They said to their father, "Go
out with them and lead them, or we will kill you." 12 He burned with
rage when he saw that his sons were pushing him to march in front
of them against his brother Jacob. 13 But afterward he remembered all
the evil lying hidden in his heart against his brother Jacob; and he did
not remember the oath he had sworn to his father and mother that he
would never plot evil against his brother Jacob. 14 In spite of all this,
Jacob did not know they were coming against him to battle, and he
was mourning for his wife Leah, until they came very near the tower
with four thousand warriors and chosen men of war. 15 The people
of Hebron sent him word: "Your brother is marching against you to
fight, with four thousand swordsmen carrying shields and weapons."
They sent this because they preferred Jacob to Esau; Jacob was the
more generous and kind of the two. 16 But Jacob would not believe it
until they came very near the tower. 17 He shut the gates of the tower,
and stood on the battlements and spoke to his brother Esau and said,
"Noble is the comfort with which you have come to comfort me for
my wife who has died. Is this the oath you swore to your father and
again to your mother before they died? You have broken the oath,
and at the moment you swore to your father you were condemned."
18 Then Esau answered and said to him, "Neither human beings nor
the animals of the earth have any oath of righteousness that, once
sworn, holds forever; every day they plot evil against each other, and
how each may kill his adversary and enemy. 19 You hate me and my
children forever. There is no keeping the tie of brotherhood with you.
20 Hear what I now declare to you: only if the boar can change its hide
and turn its bristles soft as wool, or grow horns on its head like a
stag's or a ram's, will I honor the bond of brotherhood with you. c 21
If wolves make peace with lambs so as not to devour or harm them,

and if their hearts are good toward them, then there will be peace in my heart toward you. 22 If the lion becomes the friend of the ox and makes peace with him, and is bound under one yoke with him and plows with him, then I will make peace with you. 23 When the raven becomes white as the raza, then know that I have loved you and will make peace with you. You will be rooted out, and your sons will be rooted out, and there will be no peace for you."[d] 24 When Jacob saw that Esau was so evilly disposed toward him with his heart and all his soul as to kill him, and that he had come springing like the wild boar that charges on the spear that pierces and kills it and does not recoil from it, 25 he spoke to his own men and to his servants that they should attack him and all his companions.

Notes

- a (37:1) The story of the war between Jacob's sons and Esau, in chapters 37 and 38, is also found in Testament of Judah 9 and in later Jewish tradition; Jubilees has the oldest form. Several peoples named here played a part in Maccabean wars.
- b (37:6) Aram is Syria, the ruling power in the Maccabean period.
- c (37:20) Sayings of this kind compare with the rebuke to Akiba: "Sooner will grass grow on your beard than the Messiah appear." The boar may stand for Esau.
- d (37:23) The raza is a large white bird said to eat grasshoppers.

Chapter 38

The Battle at the Tower and the Kings of Edom

1 After that Judah spoke to his father Jacob and said to him, "Bend your bow, father, and shoot your arrows and bring down the adversary and kill the enemy; and may you have the power, for we will not kill your brother, since he is like you and the same as you; let us give him this honor." 2 Then Jacob bent his bow and shot the arrow and struck his brother Esau on his right breast and killed him.[a] 3 Again he shot an arrow and struck Adoran the Aramean on the left breast, and drove him backward and killed him. 4 Then Jacob's sons went out, they and their servants, dividing themselves into companies on the four sides of the tower. 5 Judah led the way, with Naphtali, Gad, and fifty servants at his side, to the south of the tower. They struck down everyone in front of them, and no one got away. 6 Levi, Dan, and Asher went out on the east side of the tower, and fifty men

with them, and they killed the fighting men of Moab and Ammon.
7 Reuben, Issachar, and Zebulun went out on the north side of the
tower, and fifty men with them, and they killed the fighting men of
the Philistines. 8 Simeon, Benjamin, and Enoch, Reuben's son, went
out on the west side of the tower, and fifty men with them, and they
killed four hundred men of Edom and the Horites, stout warriors; and
six hundred fled, and four of Esau's sons fled with them, and left their
father lying dead, where he had fallen on the hill that is in Aduram.[b] 9
Jacob's sons pursued them to the mountains of Seir. Jacob buried his
brother on the hill that is in Aduram, and he returned to his house. 10
Jacob's sons leaned hard on Esau's sons in the highlands of Seir and
bent their necks, so that they became servants to Jacob's sons. 11 They
sent to their father to ask whether they should make peace with them
or kill them. 12 Jacob sent word to his sons to make peace. They did so
and laid the yoke of servitude on the Edomites, who paid tribute to
Jacob and his sons from then on. 13 They continued to pay tribute to
Jacob until the day he went down to Egypt. 14 The sons of Edom have
not got free of the yoke of servitude that the twelve sons of Jacob
put on them, to this day.[c] 15 These are the kings who reigned in Edom
before any king reigned over the children of Israel, in the land of
Edom. 16 Balaq, son of Beor, reigned in Edom, and the name of his city
was Danaba.[d] 17 Balaq died, and Jobab, son of Zara of Boser, reigned
in his place. 18 Jobab died, and 'Asam of the land of Teman reigned in
his place. 19 'Asam died, and 'Adath, son of Barad, who killed Midian
in the field of Moab, reigned in his place, and the name of his city
was Avith. 20 'Adath died, and Salman from 'Amaseqa reigned in his
place. 21 Salman died, and Saul of Ra'aboth by the river reigned in his
place. 22 Saul died, and Ba'elunan, son of Achbor, reigned in his place.
23 Ba'elunan, son of Achbor, died, and 'Adath reigned in his place, and
the name of his wife was Maitabith, daughter of Matarat, daughter of
Metabedza'ab. 24 These are the kings who reigned in the land of Edom.

Notes

- a (38:2) Later tradition says Esau was killed by Chushim, son of Dan, at Machpelah, when Jacob's body was brought there for burial.

- b (38:8) Aduram is the Adora of 1 Macc 13:20 in Edom, captured by John Hyrcanus, who forced the Edomites to accept circumcision. In Testament of Judah 9 the name appears as Anoniram.
- c (38:14) "To this day" is the author's own day; Edom was made tributary to Israel by John Hyrcanus.
- d (38:16) These names follow Gen 36:31–39 in the Greek form. Balaq is Bela; Danaba is Dinhabah.

Chapter 39

Joseph in Potiphar's House and in Prison

1 Jacob lived in the land of his father's wanderings, in the land of
Canaan. 2 These are the generations of Jacob. Joseph was seventeen
years old when they took him down to the land of Egypt, and
Potiphar, Pharaoh's official, the chief cook, bought him.[a] 3 He set
Joseph over all his house, and the blessing of the Lord came on the
Egyptian's house because of Joseph, and the Lord made him prosper
in everything he did. 4 The Egyptian committed everything into
Joseph's hands, for he saw that the Lord was with him and that the
Lord made him prosper in everything he did. 5 Joseph's appearance
was handsome, very beautiful was his appearance, and his master's
wife lifted up her eyes and saw Joseph, and she loved him and
begged him to be with her. 6 But he did not surrender himself. He
remembered the Lord, and what his father Jacob used to read to him
from Abraham's teachings: that no man may commit adultery with
a married woman, that death is the penalty fixed for him in heaven
before God Most High, and that his sin will be entered against him in
the eternal books before the Lord forever. 7 Joseph remembered these
words and refused to lie with her. 8 She begged him for a year, but he
refused and would not listen. 9 But she threw her arms around him
and clung to him inside the house, trying to force him to lie with her.
She had shut the doors. He left his cloak in her hands, burst through
the door, and ran out of her sight. 10 The woman saw that he would
not lie with her, and she slandered him in the presence of her lord,
saying, "Your Hebrew servant, whom you love, tried to force me so
that he might lie with me; and when I raised my voice he fled and
left his garment in my hands when I held him, and he broke through

the door." 11 The Egyptian saw Joseph's garment and the broken door
and heard his wife's words, and he threw Joseph into prison, into the
place where the prisoners the king imprisoned were kept. 12 He stayed
there in the prison, and the Lord granted Joseph the goodwill and
pity of the chief jailer, who saw that the Lord was with him and made
all his work succeed. 13 He committed everything into his hands, and
the chief of the prison guards knew nothing of what was with him,
for Joseph did everything, and the Lord brought it to completion. 14
He stayed there two years. In those days Pharaoh, king of Egypt, was
angry with his two officials, the chief butler and the chief baker, and
he put them in custody in the house of the chief cook, in the prison
where Joseph was kept. 15 The chief of the prison guards appointed
Joseph to serve them, and he served them. 16 The two of them had
a dream, the chief cupbearer and the chief baker, and they told it
to Joseph. 17 As he interpreted to them, so it happened to them, and
Pharaoh restored the chief butler to his office, and killed the chief
baker, as Joseph had interpreted to them. 18 But the chief butler forgot
Joseph in the prison, although he had told him what would happen
to him, and he did not remember to tell Pharaoh how Joseph had told
him, for he forgot.

Notes

- a (39:2) "Chief cook" renders the Greek of Gen 37:36; the Hebrew means "captain of the guard." See 34:11.

Chapter 40

Pharaoh's Dreams and Joseph's Rise

1 In those days Pharaoh dreamed two dreams in one night concerning
a famine that was to come over all the land, and he woke from
his sleep and called all the interpreters of dreams in Egypt and the
magicians, and told them his two dreams, and they were not able to
explain them. 2 Then the chief butler remembered Joseph and spoke
of him to the king, and he brought him out of the prison, and he told
his two dreams before him. 3 He told Pharaoh that the two dreams
were a single dream, and he said, "Seven years of abundance are
coming over the whole land of Egypt, and after them seven years

of famine, a famine unlike any the land has known. [4] Let Pharaoh now name officials across Egypt to collect and store grain in every town during the years of plenty. Then there will be food for the seven years of famine, and the country will not perish in the famine, which will be extremely harsh." [5] The Lord gave Joseph favor and mercy in Pharaoh's eyes, and Pharaoh said to his servants, "We will not find such a wise and discerning man as this man, for the spirit of the Lord is with him." [6] He appointed him second in all his kingdom and gave him authority over all Egypt, and had him ride in Pharaoh's second chariot. [7] He clothed him with linen garments and put a gold chain on his neck, and a herald proclaimed before him, "'El 'El wa 'Abirer," and he put a ring on his hand and made him ruler over all his house, and magnified him, and said to him: "Only on the throne will I be greater than you."[a] [8] Joseph governed all of Egypt. Pharaoh's officials, his servants, and everyone who handled the king's business loved him, because he behaved with integrity, free of pride and arrogance, showing no favoritism and accepting no bribes, and judged all the people of the land fairly. [9] Egypt enjoyed peace under Pharaoh because of Joseph. The Lord was with him and gave him favor and kindness throughout his life among everyone who knew him or heard of him, and Pharaoh's realm was well governed. There was no Satan and no wicked person in it.[b] [10] The king called Joseph's name Sephantiphans, and gave Joseph as wife the daughter of Potiphar, daughter of the priest of Heliopolis, the chief cook.[c] [11] On the day Joseph stood before Pharaoh he was thirty years old. [12] In that year Isaac died. And as Joseph had said in the interpretation of the two dreams, there were seven years of plenty over all the land of Egypt, and the land of Egypt produced abundantly, one measure yielding eighteen hundred measures. [13] Joseph gathered food into every city until they were full of grain, until they could no longer count and measure it for its great quantity.

Notes

- a (40:7) "'El 'El wa 'Abirer" probably reflects Hebrew 'el 'el wa-'abir 'el, "God, God, and the mighty one of God," an expansion of the Hebrew word abrek ("bow

the knee") in Gen 41:43. "Mighty one of God" may be a title of a great magician; compare Acts 8:10.

- b (40:9) The absence of Satan is a sign of great happiness; compare 23:29.
- c (40:10) Sephantiphans is Zaphenath-paneah (Gen 41:45). The author treats Potiphar of Gen 37:36 and Potiphera of Gen 41:45 as one man. Later Jewish legend makes Asenath a daughter of Dinah raised in his house.

Chapter 41

Judah and Tamar

1 In the second year of the second week of the forty-fifth jubilee, Judah chose a wife for his firstborn Er from the daughters of Aram, a woman named Tamar.[a] 2 Er detested her and did not sleep with her, because his own mother was a Canaanite woman and he wanted a wife from his mother's family, but his father Judah would not permit it. 3 This Er, Judah's firstborn, was wicked, and the Lord killed him. 4 Judah said to his brother Onan, "Go in to your brother's wife and do a husband's brother's duty to her, and raise up offspring for your brother." 5 Onan knew that the offspring would not be his, but his brother's only, and he went into his brother's wife's house and spilled the seed on the ground; and he was wicked in the Lord's eyes, and he killed him. 6 Judah said to Tamar, his daughter-in-law, "Stay in your father's house as a widow until my son Shelah grows up, and I will give you to him as a wife." 7 He grew up; but Bedsu'el, Judah's wife, did not allow her son Shelah to marry. And Bedsu'el, Judah's wife, died in the fifth year of this week.[b] 8 In the sixth year Judah went up to shear his sheep at Timnah. They told Tamar, "Look, your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to shear his sheep."[c] 9 She took off her widow's clothing, put on a veil, made herself up, and sat at the town gate by the road to Timnah. 10 As Judah was going along he found her and thought she was a prostitute, and he said to her, "Let me come in to you"; and she said to him, "Come in," and he went in. 11 She said to him, "Give me my pay"; and he said to her, "I have nothing in my hand but my ring on my finger, and my necklace, and the staff in my hand." 12 She said to him, "Give them to me until you send me my pay"; and he said to her, "I will send you a kid from the goats"; and he gave them to her, and went in to her, and she conceived by

him. 13 Judah went to his sheep, and she went to her father's house.
14 Judah sent a young goat by his shepherd, an Adullamite, but the
man could not find her. He asked the locals, "Where is the prostitute
who was here?" They answered, "We have no prostitute here." 15 He
returned and told him that he had not found her: "I asked the people
of the place, and they said to me, 'There is no prostitute here.'" He
said, "Let her keep them, or we will become a laughingstock." 16 When
she had completed three months, it was plain that she was pregnant,
and they told Judah, "Look, your daughter-in-law Tamar is pregnant
by prostitution." 17 Judah went to her father's house and said to her
father and her brothers, "Bring her out and let them burn her, for she
has done an unclean thing in Israel."[d] 18 When they brought her out to
burn her, she sent the ring, the necklace, and the staff to her father-in-
law, saying, "Recognize whose these are, for by him I am pregnant." 19
Judah recognized them and said, "Tamar is more righteous than I am.
Therefore let them not burn her." 20 For that reason she was not given
to Shelah, and he did not approach her again. 21 After that she bore
two sons, Perez and Zerah, in the seventh year of this second week.[e]
22 With that, the seven years of fruitfulness of which Joseph spoke to
Pharaoh were completed. 23 Judah admitted that what he had done
was wrong, since he had slept with his daughter-in-law. He found it
repulsive and conceded that he had sinned and gone astray, having
exposed his own son's robe. He began to lament and plead with the
Lord for his offense. 24 We told him in a dream that it was forgiven him
because he pleaded earnestly and lamented and did not do it again.
25 He received forgiveness because he turned from his sin and from
his ignorance, for he had transgressed greatly before our God; and
everyone who acts in this way, everyone who lies with his mother-in-
law, let them burn him with fire, so that he burns in it, for uncleanness
and pollution are on them; let them burn them with fire.[f] 26 And you,
command the children of Israel that there be no uncleanness among
them, for everyone who lies with his daughter-in-law or with his
mother-in-law has committed uncleanness; let them burn the man
who lay with her with fire, and likewise the woman, and he will turn
wrath and punishment away from Israel.[g] 27 To Judah we declared that

his two sons had not slept with her, and for that reason his line was kept going into a second generation and would not be uprooted. [28] For in singleness of eye he had gone and sought punishment, namely according to the judgment of Abraham, which he had commanded his sons: Judah had sought to burn her with fire.[h]

Notes

- a (41:1) Year 2165 from creation in Charles's count. Testament of Judah 10 says "from Mesopotamia."
- b (41:7) Bedsu'el is Bathshua; see 34:20.
- c (41:8) Year 2168 from creation in Charles's count.
- d (41:17) Burning was the penalty for a priest's daughter (Lev 21:9); the Targum Pseudo-Jonathan says Tamar was a priest's daughter. Compare 30:7.
- e (41:21) Year 2170 from creation in Charles's count.
- f (41:25) Compare Lev 20:14.
- g (41:26) Compare Lev 18:15; 20:12, which do not specify the manner of death; Gen 38:24 presupposes burning.
- h (41:28) See 20:4.

Chapter 42

The Brothers' Two Journeys to Egypt

[1] In the first year of the third week of the forty-fifth jubilee, famine began to settle on the land; the rain refused to fall at all.[a] [2] The earth turned barren, yet in Egypt there was food, since Joseph had gathered grain in the seven years of plenty and kept it safe. [3] The Egyptians came to Joseph for him to give them food, and he opened the storehouses where the grain of the first year was, and sold it to the people of the land for gold. [4] The famine was terribly severe in Canaan. Jacob heard there was grain in Egypt and sent his ten sons there to buy some for him. He did not send Benjamin, and Jacob's ten sons reached Egypt together with the others who had come. [5] Joseph recognized them, but they did not recognize him, and he spoke to them and questioned them, and said to them, "Are you not spies, and have you not come to explore the approaches of the land?" And he put them in custody. [6] After that he set them free again, and held Simeon alone and sent his nine brothers away. [7] He filled their sacks with grain, and put their gold in their sacks, and they did not know. [8] He commanded them to bring their younger brother, for they had

told him that their father was living, and their younger brother. 9
They went up from the land of Egypt and came to the land of Canaan,
and told their father all that had happened to them and how the lord
of the country had spoken harshly to them and had seized Simeon
until they should bring Benjamin. 10 Jacob said, “You have bereaved
me of my children! Joseph is gone and Simeon is gone too, and you
will take Benjamin away. Your wickedness has come on me.”[b] 11 He
said, “My son will not go down with you, in case he falls sick; for
their mother bore two sons, and one has perished, and you will take
this one from me too. If he were to catch a fever on the road, you
would bring my old age down with sorrow to death.”[c] 12 For he saw
that their money had been returned to each man in his sack, and for
this reason he was afraid to send him. 13 The famine increased and
became severe in the land of Canaan and in all lands except the land
of Egypt, for many of the Egyptians had stored up their seed for food
from the time they saw Joseph gathering seed together and putting it
in storehouses and keeping it for the years of famine. 14 The people of
Egypt fed themselves on it during the first year of their famine. 15 But
when Israel saw that the famine was very severe in the land and there
was no relief, he said to his sons, “Go again and get food for us so
that we do not die.” 16 They said, “We will not go; unless our youngest
brother goes with us, we will not go.” 17 Israel saw that if he did not
send him with them, they would all perish because of the famine. 18
Reuben said, “Hand him over to me. If I do not bring him back to you,
put my two sons to death in place of his life.” Jacob answered, “He will
not go with you.” 19 Judah stepped forward and said, “Send him with
me. If I do not bring him back, let the blame rest on me before you
for the rest of my days.” 20 He sent him along with them in the second
year of this week, on the first of the month. They reached Egypt
with the other travelers, carrying gifts: balm, almonds, terebinth nuts,
and pure honey.[d] 21 They went and stood before Joseph, and he saw
his brother Benjamin and knew him, and said to them, “Is this your
youngest brother?” They said to him, “It is he.” He said, “May the
Lord be gracious to you, my son!” 22 He sent him into his house and
brought Simeon out to them, and made a feast for them, and they

presented to him the gift they had brought in their hands. [23] They ate before him, and he gave them all a portion, but Benjamin's portion was seven times larger than any of theirs. [24] They ate and drank and got up and stayed with their donkeys. [25] Joseph devised a plan to learn their thoughts, whether thoughts of peace prevailed among them, and he said to the steward over his house, "Fill all their sacks with food, and return their money to them in their containers, and put my cup, the silver cup I drink from, in the sack of the youngest, and send them away."

Notes

- a (42:1) Year 2171 from creation in Charles's count.
- b (42:10) This interprets Gen 42:36, "All this is against me."
- c (42:11) Compare Gen 42:38: "if harm befalls him on the journey."
- d (42:20) Year 2172 from creation in Charles's count. The month is not named.

Chapter 43

Joseph Makes Himself Known

[1] He did as Joseph had instructed, filling all their sacks with grain, returning each man's money into his sack, and placing the cup in Benjamin's sack. [2] Early in the morning they left, and when they had gone from there, Joseph said to the steward of his house, "Pursue them, run and seize them, saying, 'You have repaid me evil for good; you have stolen from me the silver cup from which my lord drinks.' And bring their youngest brother back to me, and bring him quickly before I go out to my seat of judgment." [3] He ran after them and said these words to them. [4] They said to him, "God forbid that your servants should do this thing and steal any vessel from your lord's house, when the money we found in our sacks the first time we, your servants, brought back from the land of Canaan. [5] How then should we steal any vessel? Look, here we are with our sacks; search, and wherever you find the cup in the sack of any of us, let him be killed, and we and our donkeys will serve your lord." [6] He said to them, "Not so; the man with whom I find it, only he will I take as a servant, and you will return in peace to your house." [7] As he searched their containers, beginning with the eldest and ending with the youngest, it was found in Benjamin's sack. [8] They tore their clothes and loaded

their donkeys and returned to the city and came to Joseph's house,
and they all bowed down on their faces to the ground before him. 9
Joseph said to them, "You have done evil." They said, "What shall we
say and how shall we defend ourselves? Our lord has discovered the
transgression of his servants; look, we are our lord's servants, and
our donkeys too." 10 Joseph said to them, "I also fear the Lord. As for
you, go to your homes and let your brother be my servant, for you
have done evil. Do you not know that a man delights in his cup as I
do in this cup? And yet you have stolen it from me."[a] 11 Judah said, "O
my lord, let your servant, I pray, speak a word in my lord's ear: your
servant's mother bore two sons to our father; one went away and was
lost and has not been found, and he alone is left of his mother, and
our father, your servant, loves him, and his life is bound up with this
boy's life. 12 When we go to your servant our father and the boy is not
with us, he will die, and we will bring our father down with sorrow to
death. 13 Now let me, your servant, stay in place of the boy as a slave
to my lord, and let the boy go with his brothers, for I became surety
for him from the hand of your servant our father, and if I do not bring
him back, your servant will bear the blame before our father forever."
14 Joseph saw that they were all of one mind in goodness toward each
other, and he could not control himself, and he told them that he was
Joseph. 15 He spoke with them in the Hebrew language and fell on
their necks and wept. But they did not recognize him, and they began
to weep.[b] 16 He said to them, "Do not weep over me, but hurry and
bring my father to me; and you see that it is my mouth that speaks and
the eyes of my brother Benjamin that see. 17 This is only the second
year of the famine, and five more years remain with no harvest, no
fruit on the trees, and no plowing. 18 Come down quickly, you and
your households, so that you do not perish through the famine, and
do not grieve over your possessions, for the Lord sent me before you
to set things in order so that many people might live. 19 Tell my father
that I am alive. See, you can tell him the Lord has made me a father to
Pharaoh and master of his house and of the whole country of Egypt.
20 Tell my father of all my glory and all the riches and glory the Lord
has given me." 21 By the command of Pharaoh's mouth he gave them

chariots and provisions for the way, and gave them all many-colored clothing and silver. 22 To their father he sent clothing and silver and ten donkeys carrying grain, and he sent them away. 23 They went up and told their father that Joseph was alive, that he was measuring out grain to all the nations of the world, and that he ruled all of Egypt. 24 Their father could not believe it, for he was out of his mind with shock. But when he saw the wagons Joseph had sent, his spirit came back to life. He said, "It is enough for me that Joseph lives. I will go down to see him before I die."

Notes

- a (43:10) Compare Gen 44:15, "Do you not know that a man like me can divine?" The change in Jubilees may be deliberate.
- b (43:15) That Joseph spoke Hebrew is a Midrashic touch; compare Genesis Rabbah 93.

Chapter 44

Jacob Goes Down to Egypt

1 Israel left his home on the first of the third month, traveled by way of the Well of the Oath, and on the seventh of that month offered a sacrifice to the God of his father Isaac.[a] 2 Jacob remembered the dream he had seen at Bethel, and he was afraid to go down to Egypt. 3 He was considering sending word to Joseph to come to him, since he himself did not wish to go down. So he waited there seven days, in case a vision might show him whether to stay or to go down. 4 He celebrated the harvest feast of first fruits with old grain, because in all Canaan there was not a handful of seed; the famine had struck the wild animals, the livestock, and the birds, as well as human beings.[b] 5 On the sixteenth the Lord appeared to him and said to him, "Jacob, Jacob." He said, "Here I am." He said to him, "I am the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham and Isaac; do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for I will make a great nation of you there.[c] 6 I will go down with you, and I will bring you up again, and in this land you will be buried, and Joseph will close your eyes with his hands. Do not be afraid; go down to Egypt." 7 His sons and his sons' sons got up and put their father and their possessions on wagons. 8 Israel left the Well of the Oath on the sixteenth of this third month and went to the

land of Egypt. 9 Israel sent Judah ahead of him to his son Joseph to
survey the land of Goshen, for Joseph had told his brothers to come
and live there so they might be near him. 10 This was the best land
in the land of Egypt, and near him, for all of them and for the cattle
too. 11 These are the names of the sons of Jacob who went to Egypt
with their father Jacob.[d] 12 Reuben, the firstborn of Israel; and these
are the names of his sons: Enoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi — five,
counting the father. 13 Simeon and his sons; and these are the names
of his sons: Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar, and Shaul, son of
the Zephathite woman — seven.[e] 14 Levi and his sons; and these are
the names of his sons: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari — four. 15 Judah
and his sons; and these are the names of his sons: Shelah, Perez, and
Zerah — four. 16 Issachar and his sons; and these are the names of
his sons: Tola, Phua, Jasub, and Shimron — five. 17 Zebulun and his
sons; and these are the names of his sons: Sered, Elon, and Jahleel
— four. 18 These are the sons of Jacob, and their sons, born to him
by Leah in Mesopotamia: six sons, and one sister, Dinah. All the
persons descended from Leah who went to Egypt with their father
Jacob numbered twenty-nine; counting their father Jacob, thirty. 19
The sons of Zilpah, Leah's servant, wife of Jacob, whom she bore to
Jacob: Gad and Asher. 20 These are the names of their sons who went
with him to Egypt: the sons of Gad: Ziphion, Haggi, Shuni, Ezbon,
Eri, Areli, and Arodi — eight. 21 The sons of Asher: Imnah, Ishvah,
Ishvi, Beriah, and Serah, their one sister — six. 22 All the souls were
fourteen, and all those of Leah were forty-four. 23 The sons of Rachel,
wife of Jacob: Joseph and Benjamin. 24 To Joseph in Egypt, before his
father came to Egypt, were born those whom Asenath, daughter of
Potiphar, priest of Heliopolis, bore to him: Manasseh and Ephraim —
three. 25 The sons of Benjamin: Bela, Becher, Ashbel, Gera, Naaman,
Ehi, Rosh, Muppim, Huppim, and Ard — eleven. 26 All the souls of
Rachel were fourteen. 27 The sons of Bilhah, the servant of Rachel, wife
of Jacob, whom she bore to Jacob, were Dan and Naphtali. 28 These are
the names of their sons who went with them to Egypt. The sons of
Dan were Hushim, Samon, Asudi, 'Ijaka, and Salomon — six. 29 They
died in the year in which they entered Egypt, and Hushim alone was

left to Dan.[f] 30 These are the names of the sons of Naphtali: Jahziel, Guni, Jezer, Shallum, and 'Iv.[g] 31 And 'Iv, who was born after the years of famine, died in Egypt. 32 All the souls of Rachel were twenty-six. 33 All the souls of Jacob who went to Egypt were seventy souls. These are his children and his children's children, seventy in all; but five died in Egypt before Joseph and had no children. 34 In Canaan two of Judah's sons, Er and Onan, died childless. The Israelites buried those who died there, and they were counted among the seventy nations.

Notes

- a (44:1) First of month 3 is about May 21, and the seventh about May 27, in the book's 364-day calendar. The Ethiopic here reads "Haran" for the starting place, which is probably corrupt for Hebron; compare Gen 37:14. The Well of the Oath is Beersheba.
- b (44:4) The Feast of Weeks, the fifteenth of month 3 (about June 4). See Gen 46:1.
- c (44:5) The sixteenth is about June 5.
- d (44:11) The total of seventy includes Jacob himself. Another count, in Exod 1:5, reaches seventy by leaving Jacob out; Acts 7:14 has seventy-five, following the Greek. The lists below differ in places from Genesis 46, and the tallies in the Ethiopic text do not always add up.
- e (44:13) "Zephathite" means a native of the Canaanite city Zephath; compare Judg 1:17.
- f (44:29) Genesis 46:23 mentions Hushim alone.
- g (44:30) Neither Gen 46:24 nor 1 Chron 7:13 has 'Iv.

Chapter 45

Jacob in Egypt and His Death

1 On the first of the fourth month, in the second year of the third week of the forty-fifth jubilee, Israel entered Egypt, in the region of Goshen.[a] 2 Joseph went to meet his father Jacob in the land of Goshen, and fell on his father's neck and wept. 3 Israel said to Joseph, "Now I can die, having seen you. Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, the God of Abraham and of Isaac, who has not held back his kindness and favor from his servant Jacob. 4 It is enough for me that I have seen your face while I am still alive; yes, the vision I saw at Bethel is true. Blessed be the Lord my God forever and ever, and blessed be his name." 5 Joseph and his brothers ate and drank in their father's presence. Jacob was overjoyed to see Joseph eating and drinking with his brothers in front

of him, and he blessed the Maker of all things, who had kept him alive and kept all twelve of his sons for him. [6] Joseph gave his father and brothers, as a grant, the right to settle in Goshen, in Rameses, and in the whole surrounding district under his authority beneath Pharaoh. Israel and his sons lived in Goshen, the finest part of Egypt. Israel was a hundred and thirty years old when he arrived in Egypt. [7] Joseph supported his father and his brothers and also their possessions with as much bread as they needed for the seven years of the famine. [8] Egypt was devastated by the famine. In exchange for grain, Joseph acquired all the land of Egypt for Pharaoh, and took the people, their livestock, and everything else into Pharaoh's possession. [9] The years of famine were completed, and Joseph gave the people in the land seed and food so they could sow the land in the eighth year, for the river had overflowed all the land of Egypt. [10] During the seven famine years the river had not flooded and had watered only a few spots along its banks. Now it rose over its banks, the Egyptians sowed their fields, and that year the ground yielded abundant grain. [11] This was the first year of the fourth week of the forty-fifth jubilee.[b] [12] Joseph took a fifth part of the grain of the harvest for the king and left four parts for them as food and seed, and Joseph made it an ordinance for the land of Egypt until this day. [13] Israel lived in the land of Egypt seventeen years, and all the days he lived were three jubilees, a hundred and forty-seven years, and he died in the fourth year of the fifth week of the forty-fifth jubilee.[c] [14] Israel blessed his sons before he died and told them everything that would happen to them in the land of Egypt; and he made known to them what would come on them in the last days, and blessed them, and gave Joseph two portions in the land.[d] [15] He died and joined his ancestors, and was buried in the twin cave in Canaan, beside his father Abraham, in the tomb he had dug for himself in the twin cave in the region of Hebron. [16] He gave all his books and the books of his fathers to his son Levi so that he might preserve them and renew them for his children until this day.[e]

Notes

- a (45:1) The first of month 4 is about June 21 in the 364-day calendar. Year 2172 from creation in Charles's count.

- b (45:11) Year 2178 from creation in Charles's count.
- c (45:13) 3 × 49 = 147. Year 2188 from creation in Charles's count.
- d (45:14) Compare Gen 49 and 48:22.
- e (45:16) The author presents the ancestral writings as kept by the priestly line of Levi.

Chapter 46

Joseph's Death and the Oppression of Israel

1 After Jacob's death the Israelites multiplied in Egypt and became a great nation. They were united in heart: brother loved brother, and each helped the other. They increased enormously for ten weeks of years, throughout Joseph's lifetime.[a] 2 There was no Satan and no evil all the days of Joseph's life that he lived after his father Jacob, for all the Egyptians honored the children of Israel all the days of Joseph's life. 3 Joseph died aged one hundred ten. Seventeen of his years were spent in Canaan, ten as a slave, three in prison, and eighty serving the king as ruler of all Egypt. 4 He died, and all his brothers, and all that generation. 5 Before he died he ordered the Israelites to take his bones with them when they left Egypt. 6 He made them swear about his bones, for he knew that the Egyptians would not bring him out again and bury him in the land of Canaan, for Makamaron, king of Canaan, while living in the land of Assyria, fought in the valley with the king of Egypt and killed him there, and pursued the Egyptians to the gates of Ermon.[b] 7 He could not get in, because a different, newer king now ruled Egypt, a stronger man than he. So he went back to Canaan. The gates of Egypt were closed, and nobody left or entered. 8 Joseph died in the sixth week, second year, of the forty-sixth jubilee. He was buried in Egypt, and all his brothers died after him.[c] 9 In the second year of the second week of the forty-seventh jubilee, the king of Egypt marched to war against the king of Canaan. The Israelites carried out the bones of all Jacob's sons except Joseph's and buried them in the twin cave in the field on the mountain.[d] 10 Most of them returned to Egypt, but a few of them stayed in the mountains of Hebron, and your father Amram stayed with them.[e] 11 The king of Canaan was victorious over the king of Egypt, and he shut the gates of Egypt. 12 He devised an evil plan against the children of Israel, to afflict them;

and he said to the people of Egypt, 13 "See how the Israelite people
have grown more numerous and stronger than we are. Let us plan
carefully against them before they multiply further, and wear them
down with forced labor before war breaks out and they side against
us. Otherwise they will join our enemies and leave our land, for their
hearts and eyes are fixed on Canaan." 14 He appointed taskmasters
over them to wear them down with forced labor. They built strong
cities for Pharaoh, Pithom and Raamses, and rebuilt every wall and
fortification in Egypt's cities that had collapsed. 15 They made them
serve with harshness, and the more they dealt evilly with them, the
more they increased and multiplied. 16 The people of Egypt loathed
the children of Israel.

Notes

- a (46:1) Ten weeks of years is seventy years.
- b (46:6) Makamaron is unidentified. Ermon is probably Heroonpolis, near the desert. Testament of Simeon 8 says the Egyptians guarded Joseph's bones in the royal tombs, because sorcerers said that darkness would fall on Egypt if they left. The war between Egypt and Canaan here may reflect the campaigns of Rameses III.
- c (46:8) Year 2242 from creation in Charles's count.
- d (46:9) Year 2263 from creation in Charles's count.
- e (46:10) The angel speaks to Moses. The remark implies that some Hebrews were already in Canaan before the exodus.

Chapter 47

The Birth and Early Life of Moses

1 In the seventh week, in the seventh year, in the forty-seventh
jubilee, your father went out from the land of Canaan, and you were
born in the fourth week, in the sixth year of it, in the forty-eighth
jubilee; this was the time of tribulation for the children of Israel.[a] 2
Pharaoh, king of Egypt, issued an order about them that they should
throw all their newborn male children into the river. 3 They threw
them in for seven months, until the day you were born. Your mother
hid you for three months, and they informed on her. 4 She made an
ark for you and covered it with pitch and asphalt, and put it in the
reeds on the bank of the river, and she put you in it seven days,
and your mother came by night and nursed you, and by day Miriam,

your sister, guarded you from the birds. [5] In those days Tharmuth, the daughter of Pharaoh, came to bathe in the river, and she heard your voice crying, and she told her maidens to bring you out, and they brought you to her. [6] She took you out of the ark, and she had compassion on you. [7] Your sister said to her, "Shall I go and call one of the Hebrew women to nurse this baby for you?" She said to her, "Go." [8] She went and called your mother Jochebed, and she gave her wages, and she nursed you. [9] Afterward, when you had grown up, they brought you to the daughter of Pharaoh, and you became her son, and your father Amram taught you writing, and after you had completed three weeks they brought you into the royal court.[b] [10] You were three weeks of years at court, until you left the royal court and saw an Egyptian striking your friend, who was one of the children of Israel, and you killed him and hid him in the sand.[c] [11] On the second day you found two of the children of Israel quarreling, and you said to the one who was doing the wrong, "Why do you strike your brother?" [12] He was angry and indignant, and said, "Who made you a prince and a judge over us? Do you think to kill me as you killed the Egyptian yesterday?" And you were afraid and fled because of these words.

Notes

- a (47:1) The angel is speaking to Moses; "your father" is Amram. Years 2303 and 2330 from creation in Charles's count.
- b (47:9) Three weeks of years is twenty-one years.
- c (47:10) Years 2351–2372 from creation in Charles's count.

Chapter 48

From Moses' Flight to the Exodus

[1] In the sixth year of the third week of the forty-ninth jubilee you left and lived in the land of Midian for five weeks and one year. You returned to Egypt in the second week, in the second year, in the fiftieth jubilee.[a] [2] You yourself know what he said to you on Mount Sinai, and what Prince Mastema wanted to do with you when you were returning to Egypt, on the way, when you met him at the lodging place.[b] [3] Did he not with all his power seek to kill you and rescue the Egyptians from your hand, when he saw that you had been sent to carry out judgment and vengeance on the Egyptians?[c] [4] I

rescued you from his hand, and you performed the signs and wonders
you were sent to perform in Egypt against Pharaoh and all his house,
his servants and his people. 5 For Israel's sake the Lord took great
vengeance on them. He struck them with blood, frogs, lice, flies, and
painful boils that broke out in sores; he struck their livestock dead;
he sent hail that destroyed everything that grew, and locusts that
ate what the hail left, and darkness, and the death of the firstborn of
people and animals. On all their idols the Lord took vengeance and
burned them with fire.[d] 6 Everything was sent through your hand,
so that you would declare these things before they were done, and
you spoke with the king of Egypt before all his servants and before
his people. 7 Everything happened according to your words; ten great
and terrible judgments came on the land of Egypt, so that you might
carry out vengeance on it for Israel. 8 The Lord did everything for
Israel's sake and in keeping with his covenant, which he had made
with Abraham, that he would take vengeance on them as they had
brought them into bondage by force. 9 Prince Mastema stood against
you and tried to throw you into Pharaoh's hands, and he helped the
Egyptian sorcerers, and they stood up and worked before you. 10 We
allowed them to work the evils, but we did not allow the remedies
to be worked by their hands. 11 The Lord struck them with malignant
ulcers, and they were not able to stand, for we destroyed them so
that they could not perform a single sign. 12 Despite all these signs
and wonders, Prince Mastema was not put to shame, because he took
courage and cried out to the Egyptians to pursue you with all the
forces of the Egyptians, with their chariots and horses and all the
hosts of the peoples of Egypt. 13 I stood between Egypt and Israel,
and we saved Israel from Pharaoh and his people. The Lord led the
Israelites through the middle of the sea as though across dry ground.
14 All the nations he sent to chase Israel, the Lord our God hurled into
the middle of the sea, into the deep abyss below the Israelites, just
as the Egyptians had thrown their children into the river. He took
vengeance on a million of them, and a thousand strong, vigorous men
were destroyed for one nursing infant of your people whom they
had thrown into the river.[e] 15 On the fourteenth day, on the fifteenth,

on the sixteenth, on the seventeenth, and on the eighteenth, Prince Mastema was bound and imprisoned behind the children of Israel so that he could not accuse them.[f] 16 On the nineteenth we let them loose so that they could help the Egyptians and pursue the children of Israel.[g] 17 He hardened their hearts and made them stubborn, and the plan was devised by the Lord our God, so that he might strike the Egyptians and throw them into the sea. 18 On the fourteenth we bound him so that he could not accuse the children of Israel on the day when they asked the Egyptians for vessels and garments, silver vessels, gold vessels, and bronze vessels, in order to plunder the Egyptians in return for the bondage in which they had forced them to serve. 19 We did not lead the children of Israel out of Egypt empty-handed.

Notes

- a (48:1) Years 2372 and 2410 from creation in Charles's count; five weeks and one year is 36 years. Midian: Exod 2:15.
- b (48:2) "Mastema" ("hostility") is the chief of the evil spirits in this book. Here he takes the place of the Lord in Exod 4:24 (compare 17:16 above and 1 Chron 21:1 against 2 Sam 24:1).
- c (48:3) Other readers say Moses had failed to circumcise his son (so Targum Pseudo-Jonathan on Exod 4:24); the explanation in Jubilees seems to be its author's own.
- d (48:5) This lists the ten plagues of Exod 7–12.
- e (48:14) This is another case of measure-for-measure punishment; compare 4:31 and Wisdom 18:5.
- f (48:15) In the 364-day calendar these days of month 1 fall about April 4–8.
- g (48:16) About April 9.

Chapter 49

Rules for the Passover

1 Remember the commandment the Lord gave you about the Passover, that you should keep it in its season on the fourteenth of the first month, that you should kill it before evening, and that they should eat it by night, on the evening of the fifteenth, from the time of sunset.[a] 2 For on this night, the beginning of the festival and the beginning of the joy, you were eating the Passover in Egypt, when all the powers of Mastema had been let loose to kill all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, from the firstborn of Pharaoh to the firstborn of the captive

woman at the mill, and the cattle.[b] 3 This is the sign the Lord gave
them: they should not enter to kill any house on whose doorposts
they saw the blood of a lamb of the first year, but should pass over
it, so that all those in the house would be saved, because the sign of
the blood was on its doorposts. 4 The Lord's powers did everything
as the Lord commanded them, and they passed over all the children
of Israel, and the plague did not come on them to destroy any soul
among them, whether of cattle, or people, or dog. 5 The plague struck
Egypt with terrible force. Not one house in Egypt escaped a death,
and the land was full of weeping and wailing. 6 All Israel was eating
the Passover lamb's flesh and drinking wine, praising, blessing, and
thanking the Lord God of their fathers, ready to leave Egypt's yoke
and cruel slavery.[c] 7 Remember this day all the days of your life, and
keep it from year to year all the days of your life, once a year, on its
day, according to all its law, and do not put it off from day to day or
from month to month. 8 For it is an eternal ordinance, engraved on
the heavenly tablets concerning all the children of Israel, that they
should keep it every year on its day, once a year, throughout all their
generations; and there is no limit of days, for this is ordained forever.
9 Anyone who is clean, and nearby, yet fails to come and keep it on
its day, bringing an acceptable offering before the Lord and eating
and drinking in his presence at the festival, will be cut off. Since he
did not bring the Lord's offering at its set time, he will carry his
own guilt. 10 Let the Israelites come and keep the Passover at its fixed
time, on the fourteenth of the first month, in the twilight between
the two evenings, from the third part of the day until the third part
of the night. Two parts of the day belong to the light and the third
part to the evening.[d] 11 This is what the Lord commanded you, that
you should keep it between the evenings. 12 It is not permitted to kill
it during any part of the daylight, but at the time bordering on the
evening, and let them eat it in the evening until the third part of the
night, and whatever is left of all its flesh from the third part of the
night onward, let them burn with fire.[e] 13 They are not to cook it in
water, nor to eat it raw, but roasted on the fire: they are to eat it with
care, its head with its inner parts, and its feet, roasted with fire, and

not break any bone of it; for no bone of the children of Israel is to be crushed.[f] 14 For this reason the Lord commanded the children of Israel to keep the Passover on the day of its fixed time, and not to break a bone of it; for it is a festival day and a commanded day, and there is to be no passing over from day to day or month to month, but let it be kept on the day of its festival. 15 Order the Israelites to keep the Passover every year of their lives, once yearly at its fixed time. It will serve as a remembrance that pleases the Lord, and in any year in which they observe the Passover in its season exactly as he commanded, no plague will come among them to kill or strike. 16 They are not to eat it outside the Lord's sanctuary, but before the Lord's sanctuary, and all the people of the congregation of Israel are to celebrate it in its appointed season. 17 Every man who has come on its day is to eat it in the sanctuary of your God before the Lord, from twenty years old and up; for so it is written and ordained that they should eat it in the Lord's sanctuary. 18 When the children of Israel come into the land they are to possess, into the land of Canaan, and set up the Lord's tabernacle in the middle of the land in one of their tribes until the Lord's sanctuary has been built in the land, let them come and celebrate the Passover in the middle of the Lord's tabernacle, and let them kill it before the Lord from year to year. 19 In the days when the house has been built in the Lord's name in the land of their inheritance, they are to go there and kill the Passover in the evening, at sunset, at the third part of the day. 20 They are to offer its blood on the threshold of the altar and put its fat on the fire on the altar, and eat its flesh roasted with fire in the court of the house that has been sanctified in the Lord's name.[g] 21 They may not celebrate the Passover in their cities, nor in any place except before the Lord's tabernacle, or before his house where his name has dwelt; and they will not go astray from the Lord. 22 And you, Moses, order the Israelites to observe the Passover rules as you were commanded. Teach them every year the day of the festival, and the feast of unleavened bread, so that they eat unleavened bread for seven days, keep its festival, and each of those seven joyful days bring an offering before the Lord on your God's altar.[h] 23 For you celebrated this festival in haste when

you left Egypt, until you entered the wilderness of Shur; for on the shore of the sea you completed it.

Notes

- a (49:1) Month 1, day 14 is about April 4 in the 364-day calendar. The fourteenth, a Tuesday, begins at sunset the evening before.
- b (49:2) In Exod 12:29 it is the Lord himself who strikes the firstborn.
- c (49:6) This is the first mention of wine at the Passover meal. Later custom prescribes four cups; see Mishnah Pesahim 10.
- d (49:10) The Jews divided the night into three watches, about 6–10 p.m., 10 p.m.–2 a.m., and 2–6 a.m.; the matching day-parts would be 6–10 a.m., 10 a.m.–2 p.m., and 2–6 p.m. This text says the last of these belongs to the evening. "Between the evenings" (Exod 12:6) was read by the Sadducees and Samaritans as between sunset and full dark, but by the Pharisees as the afternoon (about 3–6 p.m.).
- e (49:12) The rabbis limited the eating to midnight.
- f (49:13) The Latin, which is to be preferred, reads "There shall be no tribulation among the children of Israel on this day." "With care" renders a Greek word; the Hebrew of Exod 12:11 is "in haste."
- g (49:20) In later times the lamb was killed in the Temple but eaten in houses in Jerusalem, because of the great numbers of pilgrims.
- h (49:22) The Ethiopic is corrupt here; the Latin reads "during its days and during."

Chapter 50

The Jubilees and the Sabbath

1 After this law I made known to you the days of the Sabbaths in the desert of Sin, which is between Elim and Sinai.[a] 2 I told you of the Sabbaths of the land on Mount Sinai, and I told you of the jubilee years in the sabbaths of years; but I have not told you the year of it until you enter the land you are to possess.[b] 3 The land too will keep its sabbaths while they live on it, and they will know the jubilee year.[c] 4 For this reason I have set out for you the year-weeks, the years, and the jubilees: there have been forty-nine jubilees from the days of Adam until this day, and one week and two years; and there are still forty years to come for learning the commandments of the Lord, until they cross over into the land of Canaan, crossing the Jordan to the west.[d] 5 The jubilees will pass by until Israel is cleansed from all guilt of fornication, uncleanness, pollution, sin, and error, and lives with confidence in all the land, and there will be no more Satan or any evil one, and the land will be clean from that time forever.[e] 6 Now look, the

commandment about the Sabbaths: I have written it down for you, with all the judgments of its laws. 7 For six days you will work, but the seventh day is the Sabbath of the Lord your God. You will do no work of any kind on that day, neither you, your sons, your male and female servants, your livestock, nor the foreigner living with you. 8 The man who does any work on it will die; whoever desecrates that day, whoever lies with his wife, or whoever says he will do something on it, that he will set out on a journey on it for buying or selling; and whoever draws water on it that he had not prepared for himself on the sixth day, and whoever picks up any burden to carry it out of his tent or out of his house, will die.[f] 9 Do no work whatever on the Sabbath, other than what you made ready on the sixth day, so that you can eat, drink, rest, and refrain from all labor that day, and bless the Lord your God, who gave you a day of festival and a holy day. This day, among all their days, is a day of the holy kingdom for all Israel, forever. 10 For great is the honor the Lord has given to Israel, that they should eat, drink, and be satisfied on this festival day, and rest on it from all labor that belongs to the labor of human beings, except burning incense and bringing offerings and sacrifices before the Lord for days and for Sabbaths. 11 This work alone is to be done on the Sabbath days in the sanctuary of the Lord your God, so that they may atone for Israel with sacrifice continually from day to day, as a memorial pleasing before the Lord, and that he may receive them always from day to day as you have been commanded.[g] 12 Every man who does any work on it, or goes on a journey, or tills his farm, whether in his house or any other place, and whoever lights a fire, or rides on any animal, or travels by ship on the sea, and whoever strikes or kills anything, or slaughters a beast or a bird, or whoever catches an animal or a bird or a fish, or whoever fasts or makes war on the Sabbaths:[h] 13 the man who does any of these things on the Sabbath will die, so that the children of Israel may keep the Sabbaths according to the commandments about the Sabbaths of the land, as it is written on the tablets that he gave into my hands, so that I should write out for you the laws of the seasons and the seasons according to the division of their days. This completes the account of the division of the days.

Notes

- a (50:1) Exod 16:1.
- b (50:2) Lev 25:8.
- c (50:3) Lev 26:34.
- d (50:4) The count is 49 × 49 + 7 + 2 = 2410 years from creation to the present moment in the story, with forty more years to the entry into Canaan, at 2450. A "year-week" is seven years.
- e (50:5) This points to the messianic age; compare 1:29 and 23:26–30.
- f (50:8) The rule against marital relations on the Sabbath is still followed by the Samaritans; the Mishnah teaches the opposite. Later rabbinic law allowed a journey of 2,000 cubits on the Sabbath (about 3,000 feet, a little over half a mile, or about 900 meters; the "Sabbath day's journey" of Acts 1:12). Buying and selling were forbidden by Nehemiah (Neh 10:31; 13:15–22). Drawing water is forbidden by the Karaite Jews.
- g (50:11) Compare Num 28:9–10 and Matt 12:5.
- h (50:12) Fire is forbidden in Exod 35:3. Riding on an animal is forbidden by the oral law. In the Maccabean wars the rule against fighting was at first kept strictly (1 Macc 2:31–38) and then relaxed (1 Macc 2:41).

2 Enoch

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 There was once a wise man and master craftsman whom the Lord[a] loved and welcomed, so that he might see the highest dwellings and witness for himself the wise, great, unimaginable, and unchanging kingdom of God Almighty; the astonishing, glorious, shining, and many-eyed station of the Lord's servants; the unapproachable throne of the Lord; the ranks and appearances of the bodiless hosts; the unspeakable service of the multitude of the elements; the many appearances and the inexpressible singing of the host of Cherubim; and the boundless light. 2 At that time, he says, when I had finished my 165th year, I fathered my son Methuselah.[b] 3 After that, I lived another two hundred years, so that my whole life came to 365 years. 4 On the first day of the month I was alone at home, resting on my bed, and I fell asleep. 5 While I slept, a great sorrow rose up in my heart, and in my sleep I wept, and I could not understand what this sorrow was or what was going to happen to me. 6 Then two men appeared to me, enormous, bigger than anyone I had ever seen on earth. Their faces shone like the sun, and their eyes were like burning lamps. Fire came from their mouths. Their clothing was a kind of singing, and its look was purple; their wings were brighter than gold, and their hands whiter than snow. 7 They stood at the head of my bed and began to call me by name. 8 I got up from my sleep and saw those two men clearly, standing before me. 9 I greeted them, and I was seized with fear; my face changed with terror. The men said to me, 10 "Take courage, Enoch, and do not be afraid. The eternal God has sent us to you, and look: today you will go up with us into heaven. You must tell your sons and all your household everything they are to do at home without you, and let no one come looking for you until the Lord brings you back to them." 11 I hurried to obey them and went out of my house. I went

to the doors, as I was told, and called my sons Methuselah, Regim,[c] and Gaidad, and told them all the marvels the men had said to me.

Notes

- a (1:1) The Slavonic text uses *Gospod'*, "Lord," where a Hebrew original would probably have had Yahweh, and *Bog*, "God." The Slavonic translation never writes the Hebrew name, so "Yahweh" is not supplied.
- b (1:2) "Methuselah" (Hebrew *Metushelach*) is a name of uncertain meaning, sometimes explained as "man of the spear." In Genesis 5:21 Enoch fathers him at the age of sixty-five; the 165 here is the figure given in the Septuagint's chronology.
- c (1:11) "Regim" and "Gaidad" appear as the names of Enoch's other sons in the Slavonic. Their meanings are not known; they have no counterpart in Genesis 5, which names only Methuselah as Enoch's son.

Chapter 2

1 "Listen to me, my children. I do not know where I am going or what will happen to me. So now, my children, I tell you: do not turn away from God to follow the empty idols, who did not make heaven and earth. They will perish, and so will those who worship them. May the Lord make your hearts steady in the fear of him. And now, my children, let no one try to look for me until the Lord brings me back to you."

Chapter 3

1 When Enoch had said all this to his sons, the angels lifted him onto their wings and carried him up to the first heaven, and set him down on the clouds. I looked down there, and then looked higher, and I saw the upper air. They set me in the first heaven and showed me a vast sea, greater than any sea on earth.

Chapter 4

1 They brought before me the elders and rulers of the star orders, and they showed me two hundred angels who govern the stars and their duties in the heavens. These angels fly on their wings and go around all who travel by sea.

Chapter 5

1 From there I looked down and saw the storehouses of the snow, the
angels who guard the fearsome vaults, and the clouds from which the
snow comes out and into which it goes back.

Chapter 6

1 They showed me the storehouse of the dew, which looked like olive
oil, and its form, which resembled all the flowers of the earth. I also
saw many angels guarding the storehouses of these things, and how
they are made to shut and open.

Chapter 7

1 Then the men took me and led me up into the second heaven. They
showed me a darkness greater than the darkness of the earth, and
there I saw prisoners hanging, under guard, waiting for the great
and endless judgment. These spirits looked dark, darker than earthly
darkness, and they wept without stopping at every hour. 2 I said to
the men who were with me, "Why are these being tormented without
end?" They answered me, "These are the rebels against God, who did
not obey God's commands but followed their own will, and turned
aside with their prince, who is also chained up in the fifth heaven." 3
I felt a great pity for them. They bowed to me and said, "Man of God,
pray for us to the Lord." I answered them, "Who am I, a mortal man,
that I should pray for angels? Who knows where I am going, or what
will happen to me? And who will pray for me?"

Chapter 8

1 Then the men led me from there up into the third heaven and put me
down. I looked downward and saw the produce of that place, so good
that nothing like it has ever been known. 2 I saw all the trees with
their fragrant blossoms, and I looked at their fruit, which smelled
sweet, and at all the food they bore, which gave off a scented steam. 3
In the middle of the trees stood the tree of life, in the spot where the
Lord rests when he goes up into Paradise.[a] This tree is indescribably
good and fragrant, more beautifully made than anything that exists.
On every side it is golden and crimson and fiery in appearance, and

it covers everything; it bears some of every fruit. [4] Its root is in the garden at the end of the earth. [5] Paradise lies between what decays and what does not decay. [6] Two springs come out of it, one sending out honey and milk, the other oil and wine. They divide into four streams, which flow on quietly and go down into the Paradise of Eden, between what decays and what does not decay. [7] From there they go out over the earth, and they circle round as the other elements do. [8] In that place there is no tree without fruit, and every spot is blessed. [9] Three hundred very bright angels guard the garden, and with endless sweet singing and voices that never fall silent they serve the Lord every day and hour. [10] I said, "How very sweet this place is!" And the men said to me,

Notes

- a (8:3) "Paradise" comes from an old Persian word for an enclosed garden; the Greek *paradeisos* is used for the garden of Eden in the Septuagint (Genesis 2:8). In Jewish writings of this period Paradise is often placed in the third heaven; compare 2 Corinthians 12:2–4.

Chapter 9

[1] "Enoch, this place has been prepared for the righteous: those who put up with every kind of insult from people who provoke them to anger; who turn their eyes away from wrongdoing; who judge fairly, give bread to the hungry, clothe the naked, lift up the fallen, and help orphans who have been wronged; who walk blamelessly before the Lord and serve him alone. This place is prepared for them as an everlasting inheritance."

Chapter 10

[1] Then the two men led me up to the northern side and showed me a most terrible place. It held every kind of torment: cruel darkness and gloom without a gleam of light, a smoky fire that blazed upward without stopping, and a river of fire pouring out. The whole place was fire everywhere, and everywhere there was frost and ice, thirst and shivering. The chains were very cruel, and the spirits that guarded it were frightening and merciless, with angry weapons and pitiless torture. And I said, [2] "Woe, woe! How terrible this place is!" [3] The

men said to me, “Enoch, this place has been prepared for those who dishonor God: those who commit unnatural sin on earth, corrupting boys in the manner of Sodom, and those who practice magic, charms, and diabolical sorcery, and boast of their evil deeds; thieves, liars, slanderers, the envious, the resentful, the sexually immoral, and murderers; those who, under a curse, steal people’s souls; those who, seeing the poor, seize their possessions and grow rich while harming them for other people’s goods; those who could have fed the empty but let the hungry die, who could have clothed them but stripped the naked; and those who did not know their Creator and bowed to gods without soul or life, who can neither see nor hear, empty gods, who also carved idols and bowed down to unclean handiwork. For all of these this place is prepared among the others, as an everlasting inheritance.”

Chapter 11

1 Next the men took me and led me up into the fourth heaven, and showed me all the successive movements and all the rays of light from the sun and the moon. 2 I measured their movements and compared their light, and I saw that the sun’s light is greater than the moon’s. 3 Its circle and the wheels on which it always travels are like the wind rushing past with astonishing speed, and day and night it has no rest. 4 Four great stars accompany its going out and its return, and under each star are a thousand stars, to the right of the sun’s wheel; and four more to the left, each with a thousand stars under it, eight thousand in all, going out continually with the sun. 5 By day fifteen myriads of angels[a] attend it, and by night a thousand. 6 Six-winged ones go out ahead of the sun’s wheel together with the angels, into the flames of fire, and a hundred angels light the sun and set it ablaze.

Notes

- a (11:5) A “myriad” is ten thousand, so fifteen myriads is 150,000. The Slavonic reads the same way in the printed text, though the numbers in this passage vary from copy to copy.

Chapter 12

1 I looked again and saw other flying creatures that belong to the sun. Their names are Phoenixes[a] and Chalkydri,[b] marvelous and wonderful. They have the feet and tails of lions and the heads of crocodiles, and their color is purple, like a rainbow. Their size is nine hundred measures. Their wings are like those of angels, twelve on each. They attend and accompany the sun, carrying heat and dew, as God orders them. 2 In this way the sun turns and travels and rises beneath the heaven, and its course goes under the earth, with the light of its rays shining without end.

Notes

- a (12:1) The Greek *phoinix* is the legendary bird of Egypt that dies in fire and is reborn from its own ashes; here it is a winged creature serving the sun.
- b (12:1) "Chalkydri" is a Greek-looking word, perhaps from *chalkos*, "bronze," or from a form of *chalkis*, a kind of snake or lizard. The creatures are known only from this book.

Chapter 13

1 The men carried me eastward and set me at the gates of the sun, where the sun goes out according to the order of the seasons, the circuit of the months of the whole year, and the number of the hours of day and night. 2 I saw six gates standing open, and each gate measured about seven miles.[a] I measured them accurately and understood how large they are. Through these the sun goes out and travels west, and is evened out, and rises through all the months, and turns back from the six gates according to the succession of the seasons. In this way the whole year is completed after the four seasons have come round.

Notes

- a (13:2) The Slavonic gives "sixty-one stadia and a quarter" (*stadii*, from the Greek *stadion*, about 185 meters or 607 feet), which comes to about 11.3 kilometers or 7 miles.

Chapter 14

1 Again the men led me away to the western regions and showed me six great gates standing open, matching the eastern gates, opposite

the place where the sun sets, corresponding to the number of days, 365 and a quarter. [2] So again the sun goes down to the western gates and draws its light, the greatness of its brightness, beneath the earth. For the crown of its shining stays in heaven with the Lord, guarded by four hundred angels, while the sun goes around on its wheel under the earth. It stays seven long hours in the night, and spends half of its course under the earth. When it reaches the approach to the east in the eighth hour of the night (about two in the morning),[a] it brings its lights and the crown of its shining, and the sun blazes more than fire.

Notes

- a (14:2) In ancient reckoning the night hours were counted from sunset, so the eighth hour of the night falls between about one and two in the morning; the text's figures for the sun's night course are not exact.

Chapter 15

[1] Then the creatures of the sun, the Phoenixes and Chalkydri, burst into song. Because of this every bird flaps its wings, rejoicing over the giver of light, and at the Lord's command they sang. [2] The giver of light comes to bring brightness to the whole world. The morning watch takes shape, which is the rays of the sun, and the sun of the earth goes out and takes up its brightness to light the whole face of the earth. They showed me this reckoning of the sun's course. [3] The gates it enters are the great gates for reckoning the hours of the year. For this reason the sun is a great creation, whose cycle lasts twenty-eight years[a] and then begins again from the start.

Notes

- a (15:3) The twenty-eight-year "great circle" of the sun is the period after which the days of the week return to the same dates in the Julian calendar (7 × 4 = 28). The next chapter gives a second cycle of 532 years, found by multiplying 28 by 19.

Chapter 16

[1] The men showed me the other course, that of the moon: twelve great gates, crowned from west to east, through which the moon goes in and out at its regular times. [2] It enters the first gate to the western places of the sun, with exactly thirty-one days at the first gate; at the second, exactly thirty-one days; at the third, exactly thirty; at

the fourth, exactly thirty; at the fifth, exactly thirty-one; at the sixth, exactly thirty-one; at the seventh, exactly thirty; at the eighth, exactly thirty-one; at the ninth, exactly thirty-one; at the tenth, exactly thirty; at the eleventh, exactly thirty-one; and at the twelfth, exactly twenty-eight. [3] It passes through the western gates in the same order and number as the eastern ones, and completes the 365 and a quarter days of the solar year, whereas the lunar year has 354. Twelve days are therefore missing from the solar circle, and these are the moon's extra days for the whole year. [4] So also the great circle contains 532 years. [5] The quarter day is left out for three years, and the fourth year makes it up exactly.[a] [6] For this reason they are taken outside heaven for three years and are not added to the number of days, because they alter the time of the years by two new months at the completion and two others at the reduction. [7] When the western gates are finished, it returns and goes to the eastern lights. So it travels day and night around the heavenly circles, lower than all the circles, faster than the winds of heaven, and than the spirits, the elements, and the flying angels; every angel has six wings. [8] It has a sevenfold course in nineteen years.

Notes

- a (16:5) This verse, on the leap-year day, is missing from the shorter recension.

Chapter 17

[1] In the middle of the heavens I saw armed soldiers who serve the Lord, with drums and pipes, with ceaseless sweet voices and many kinds of singing that cannot be described, which amazes every mind; the singing of those angels is so wonderful and marvelous. I listened to it with delight.

Chapter 18

[1] The men took me up into the fifth heaven and set me down. There I saw many countless soldiers called Grigori,[a] who looked like human beings, though their size was greater than that of great giants. Their faces were withered, and their mouths were always silent. There was no worship in the fifth heaven. I said to the men who were with me,

2 "Why are these so withered, with sad faces and silent mouths, and why is there no worship in this heaven?" 3 They said to me, "These are the Grigori, who with their prince Satanail[b] rejected the Lord of light. After them come those who are held in great darkness in the second heaven. Three of them went down to earth from the Lord's throne, to the place Ermon,[c] and broke their vows on the shoulder of Mount Ermon. They saw how beautiful the daughters of men were and took wives for themselves, and defiled the earth with their deeds. In every age of their lives they brought lawlessness and unnatural mixing, and giants were born, marvelously huge men, and great hatred." 4 "For this God judged them with a great judgment, and they weep for their brothers. They will be punished on the Lord's great day." 5 I said to the Grigori, "I have seen your brothers and their deeds and their great torments, and I prayed for them, but the Lord has condemned them to be under the earth until the present heaven and earth come to an end forever." 6 I said, "Brothers, why do you wait? Why do you not serve in the presence of the Lord, and why have you not offered your service before the Lord's face, in case you anger your Lord completely?" 7 They listened to my warning and spoke to the four ranks in heaven. And just then, as I stood with the two men, four trumpets sounded together with a great voice, and the Grigori burst into song with one voice. Their voice rose before the Lord, pitiful and moving.

Notes

- a (18:1) "Grigori" comes from the Greek *egregoroi*, "watchers" or "wakeful ones," the name given in 1 Enoch to the angels who came down to earth (compare Daniel 4:13, "a watcher, a holy one").
- b (18:3) "Satanail" is Satan with the divine ending *-el* ("God"), the name of the fallen leader in several Slavonic and Jewish writings; "Satan" itself is Hebrew for "adversary."
- c (18:3) "Ermon" is the Slavonic form of Hermon (Hebrew *Chermon*, "sacred" or "forbidden place"), the mountain in 1 Enoch 6 where the watchers swore their oath.

Chapter 19

1 From there the men took me and carried me up to the sixth heaven. There I saw seven bands of angels, very bright and glorious, their faces shining more than the sun, glistening; there is no difference

among them in face, behavior, or dress. These arrange the orders of things, and study the courses of the stars, the changes of the moon, the turning of the sun, and the good government of the world. 2 When they see evildoing they give commands and teaching, with sweet, loud singing and all kinds of songs of praise. 3 These are the archangels, who are above the angels. They measure all life in heaven and on earth. There are the angels appointed over the seasons and years, the angels over rivers and sea, over the fruit of the earth, and over every plant, giving food to every living thing; and the angels who write down all the souls of people, all their deeds, and their lives before the Lord. In their midst are six Phoenixes, six Cherubim, and six six-winged ones, always singing together with one voice, and their singing cannot be described. They rejoice before the Lord at his footstool.

Chapter 20

1 Then the two men lifted me from there up to the seventh heaven. There I saw a very great light and fiery troops of great archangels, bodiless powers, dominions, orders and authorities, Cherubim and Seraphim, thrones and many-eyed ones, nine regiments, the Ioanit[a] stations of light. I became afraid and began to tremble with great terror. The men took me and led me after them, and said to me, 2 "Take courage, Enoch; do not be afraid." They showed me the Lord from far away, sitting on his very high throne. For what is there in the tenth heaven, since the Lord lives there? 3 In the tenth heaven is God, who in the Hebrew language is called Aravat.[b] 4 All the heavenly troops would come and stand on the ten steps according to their rank, and bow down to the Lord, and go back again to their places with joy and gladness, singing songs in the boundless light with small, soft voices, serving him gloriously.

Notes

- a (20:1) "Ioanit" is an obscure word in the Slavonic copies. Its meaning is unknown, and it may be a miscopied form of an earlier name.
- b (20:3) "Aravat" or "Aravoth" (Hebrew *aravot*) is a word used in Psalm 68:4 and in later Jewish writings for the highest of the heavens, where God lives. Its original meaning may be "steppes" or "clouds."

Chapter 21

1 The Cherubim and Seraphim stand around the throne, the six-
winged and many-eyed ones. They never leave but stand before the
Lord's face doing his will; they cover his whole throne and sing with
a gentle voice before the Lord: "Holy, holy, holy, Lord, Ruler of hosts;
the heavens and the earth are full of your glory." 2 When I had seen all
these things, the men said to me, "Enoch, we have been commanded
to travel with you only this far." Then the men went away from
me, and I did not see them again. 3 I was left alone at the edge of
the seventh heaven. I became afraid and fell on my face and said to
myself, "Woe is me! What has happened to me?" 4 Then the Lord
sent one of his glorious ones, the archangel Gabriel,[a] who said to me,
"Take courage, Enoch; do not be afraid. Get up, and come with me,
and stand before the Lord's face forever." 5 I answered him and said
to myself, "My lord, my soul has left me from terror and trembling." I
called out to the men who had led me up to this place; I had relied on
them, and it was with them that I was going before the Lord's face.
6 Gabriel caught me up like a leaf caught by the wind, and set me
before the Lord's face. 7 I saw the eighth heaven, which in the Hebrew
language is called Muzaloth,[b] the changer of seasons, of drought and
of wet, with the twelve signs of the circle of the sky, which lie above
the seventh heaven. 8 I saw the ninth heaven, which in Hebrew is
called Kuchavim,[c] where the heavenly homes of the twelve signs of
the circle of the sky are.

Notes

- a (21:4) "Gabriel" (Hebrew *Gavri'el*) means "God is my strong man" or "strength of God."
- b (21:7) "Muzaloth" is the Hebrew *mazzalot*, the "constellations" or "signs" of 2 Kings 23:5.
- c (21:8) "Kuchavim" is Hebrew *kokhavim*, "stars."

Chapter 22

1 In the tenth heaven, which is called Aravoth, I saw the appearance
of the Lord's face. It was like iron heated in a fire and taken out,
throwing off sparks, and burning. 2 So, in a moment of eternity, I
saw the Lord's face; but the Lord's face cannot be described. It is

marvelous, awesome, and very, very terrible. [3] Who am I to tell of the Lord's unspeakable being and his wonderful face? I cannot tell of the number of his many instructions or his various voices, or of his very great throne, not made by hands, or of the number of those standing around him, the troops of Cherubim and Seraphim, or of their unceasing singing, or of his unchanging beauty. Who could tell of the unspeakable greatness of his glory? [4] I fell face down and bowed to the Lord, and the Lord said to me with his own lips, [5] "Take courage, Enoch; do not be afraid. Get up, and stand before my face forever." [6] Then the chief commander Michael[a] lifted me up and led me before the Lord's face. [7] The Lord said to his servants, testing them, "Let Enoch stand before my face forever." The glorious ones bowed to the Lord and said, "Let Enoch go according to your word." [8] The Lord said to Michael, "Go, take Enoch out of his earthly clothes, anoint him with my sweet ointment, and put him into the clothes of my glory." [9] Michael did as the Lord told him. He anointed me and dressed me. The appearance of that ointment was brighter than the great light, and it was like sweet dew, with a gentle scent, shining like a sunbeam. I looked at myself, and I had become like one of his glorious ones. [10] The Lord called one of his archangels by name, Pravuil,[b] whose wisdom was quicker than that of the other archangels, and who wrote down all the Lord's deeds. The Lord said to Pravuil, "Bring out the books from my storehouses, and a pen for quick writing, and give it to Enoch; deliver to him the choice and comforting books from your hand."

Notes

- a (22:6) "Michael" (Hebrew *Mikha'el*) means "Who is like God?" The Slavonic title *arkhistratig* is the Greek *archistrategos*, "chief commander."
- b (22:10) "Pravuil" is a name found only in this book; it may be related to the Jewish angel name "Vretil," and its meaning is uncertain.

Chapter 23

[1] He told me all the works of heaven, earth, and sea, and all the elements, their paths and movements; the rumblings of thunder; the sun and moon, the courses and changes of the stars; the seasons, years, days, and hours; the rising of the winds; the number of the angels

and the making of their songs; and everything human, the language of every human song and life, the commandments, the teachings, and the sweet-voiced singing, and all that is fitting to learn. 2 Pravuil said to me, "All the things I have told you, we have written down. Sit down and write out all the souls of mankind, however many are born, and the places prepared for them forever; for all souls are prepared for eternity, before the world was formed." 3 I worked for sixty days and nights, and I wrote everything out accurately and wrote 366 books.[a]

Notes

- a (23:3) The Slavonic reads "double thirty days and thirty nights"; some copies read simply "thirty days and thirty nights." The number of books also varies from copy to copy.

Chapter 24

1 The Lord called me and said to me, "Enoch, sit down on my left, with Gabriel." 2 I bowed to the Lord, and the Lord said to me, "Enoch, my beloved, all that you see, all that stands finished, I tell to you even before the very beginning: everything I created from non-being, and the visible things from the invisible." 3 "Hear, Enoch, and take in these words of mine. I have not told my secret even to my angels, and I have not told them how they arose, or about my endless kingdom, and they have not understood my creating, which I am telling you today." 4 "For before anything was visible, I alone used to move among the invisible things, like the sun from east to west and from west to east." 5 "But even the sun has peace in itself, while I found no peace, because I was creating everything. I had the idea of laying foundations and of making the visible creation."

Chapter 25

1 "In the very lowest parts I commanded that the visible things should come down from the invisible, and Adoil[a] came down, very great, and I saw him, and look, he had a belly of great light." 2 "I said to him, 'Come undone, Adoil, and let the visible come out of you.'" 3 "He came undone, and a great light came out. I was in the middle of the great light. And as light is born from light, a great age came forth and showed all the creation I had thought of making." 4 "I saw that it was

good." [5] "I placed a throne for myself and took my seat on it. I said to the light, 'Go up from there, higher, and fix yourself high above the throne, and be a foundation for the highest things.'" [6] "Above the light there is nothing else. Then I bent over and looked up from my throne."

Notes

- a (25:1) "Adoil" is a name found only in this book. Its meaning is unknown; some have suggested a connection with the Hebrew *Adonai* ("my Lord") or with a word meaning "the Lord's hand." The idea of God's own substance giving rise to the world is unique to this book.

Chapter 26

[1] "I called the very lowest a second time and said, 'Let Archas[a] come out, firm,' and he came out firm from the invisible." [2] "Archas came out, hard, heavy, and very red." [3] "I said, 'Be opened, Archas, and let there be born from you.' He came undone, and an age came forth, very great and very dark, bearing the creation of all the lower things. I saw that it was good, and I said to him," [4] "'Go down from there, make yourself firm, and be the foundation for the lower things.' It happened, and he went down and fixed himself and became the foundation for the lower things; and below the darkness there is nothing else."

Notes

- a (26:1) "Archas" is of uncertain meaning; some have taken it from Greek *archē* ("beginning"), others from Aramaic *arqa* ("earth"). Here it is the dark, heavy counterpart to Adoil.

Chapter 27

[1] "I commanded that something be taken from the light and the darkness, and I said, 'Become thick,' and so it was. I spread it out with the light, and it became water. I spread it out over the darkness, below the light, and then I made the waters firm, that is, the bottomless deep. I made a foundation of light around the water and created seven circles inside it, and I made the water look like crystal, wet and dry, that is, like glass. I made the circling of the waters and the other elements, and I showed each of them its road, and each of the seven stars its own heaven, so that they would travel in this way. And I saw that it was good." [2] "I separated the light from the darkness, in the middle

of the water, this way and that. I told the light to be the day and the darkness to be the night. There was evening and there was morning, the first day."

Chapter 28

[1] "Then I made the circle of the heavens firm, and I made the lower water, the water under heaven, gather itself into one mass, and the chaos become dry, and it was so." [2] "Out of the waves I made hard, huge rock, and from the rock I piled up the dry land. The dry land I called earth, and the middle of the earth I called the abyss, that is, the bottomless. I gathered the sea in one place and bound it together with a yoke." [3] "I said to the sea, 'Look, I am giving you your eternal limits, and you will not break loose from your component parts.'" [4] "So I made the firmament firm. This day I called the first created day (Sunday).[a]"

Notes

- a (28:4) The weekday names appear as bracketed additions in the earlier printed English text of this book, and are probably glosses added by copyists. The days of creation run from Sunday to Friday, with the seventh day, the Sabbath, in chapter 32.

Chapter 29

[1] "For all the heavenly troops I shaped the image and substance of fire. My eye looked at the very hard, firm rock, and from the flash of my eye the lightning received its wonderful nature: it is both fire in water and water in fire, and neither puts out the other or dries it up. This is why lightning is brighter than the sun, softer than water, and firmer than hard rock." [2] "From the rock I cut off a great fire, and from the fire I made the ranks of the bodiless angels in ten troops. Their weapons are fire, and their clothing is burning flame. I commanded each one to stand in his own rank." [3] "One of the angels, from the rank of the angels, turned away with the rank that was under him and conceived an impossible thought: to set his throne higher than the clouds above the earth, so that he might become equal in rank to my power." [4] "I threw him down from the height with his angels, and he has been flying in the air ever since, above the bottomless deep."

Chapter 30

1 "On the third day I commanded the earth to grow great, fruitful trees, and hills, and seed for sowing. I planted Paradise and fenced it in, and I placed flaming angels as armed guards. In this way I made new growth." 2 "Then evening came, and morning came, the fourth day." 3 "(Wednesday.) On the fourth day I commanded that there should be great lights on the heavenly circles." 4 "On the first, uppermost circle I put the star of Kruno,[a] on the second Aphrodit, on the third Aris, on the fifth Zoues, on the sixth Ermis, and on the seventh, the lowest, the moon, and I adorned it with the lesser stars." 5 "On the lower circle I placed the sun to give light to the day, and set the moon and the stars to give light to the night." 6 "I made the sun go through each of the twelve constellations, and I appointed the succession of the months with their names and lives, their thunderings, and the marking of their hours, and how they should follow one another." 7 "Then evening came, and morning came, the fifth day." 8 "(Thursday.) On the fifth day I commanded the sea to bring forth fish, and birds of many kinds with feathers, and all the animals that creep over the earth, going about on four legs, and soaring in the air, male and female, and every soul that breathes the spirit of life." 9 "Then evening came, and morning came, the sixth day." 10 "(Friday.) On the sixth day I commanded my wisdom to make man from seven substances: first, his flesh from the earth; second, his blood from the dew; third, his eyes from the sun; fourth, his bones from stone; fifth, his intelligence from the swiftness of the angels and from cloud; sixth, his veins and his hair from the grass of the earth; seventh, his soul from my breath and from the wind." 11 "I gave him seven natures: hearing to the flesh, sight to the eyes, smell to the soul, touch to the veins, taste to the blood, endurance to the bones, and enjoyment to the intelligence." 12 "I thought of a clever saying to say: I made man from both invisible and visible nature; his death and life and image come from both. He knows speech like a created thing; small in greatness and again great in smallness. I placed him on the earth as a second angel, honored, great, and glorious, and I appointed him ruler to rule on earth and to have my wisdom. There was none like him on earth among all my creatures." 13 "I gave him

a name made from the four parts, from east, west, south, and north, and I appointed four special stars for him. I called his name Adam,[b] and showed him the two ways, the light and the darkness, and I told him," 14 "'This is good, and that is bad,' so that I might learn whether he has love for me or hatred, and it might become clear which of his race love me." 15 "For I have seen his nature, but he has not seen his own nature. Because he does not see it, he will sin worse. And I said, 'After sin, what is there but death?'" 16 "I put sleep on him, and he fell asleep. I took a rib from him and made him a wife, so that death would come to him through his wife. I took his last word and called her name 'mother,' that is, Eve.[c]"

Notes

- a (30:4) These are the Greek planet names in Slavonic spelling, namely Kronos (Saturn), Aphrodite (Venus), Ares (Mars), Zeus (Jupiter), and Hermes (Mercury). The list skips the fourth circle, which is presumably the sun's, mentioned in the next verse.
- b (30:13) "Adam" is Hebrew for "man," related to *adamah*, "ground." Here the four letters of the Greek name (A-D-A-M) are taken to stand for the four directions: *anatole* (east), *dysis* (west), *arktos* (north), and *mesembria* (south). The same idea appears in later Jewish and Christian writings.
- c (30:16) "Eve" (Hebrew *Chavvah*, "life" or "living") is called "mother of all living" in Genesis 3:20. The Slavonic gives "Eva."

Chapter 31

1 "Adam has life on earth, and I made a garden in Eden, in the east, so that he might keep the covenant and observe the command." 2 "I opened the heavens to him, so that he could see the angels singing the song of victory, and the light without shadow." 3 "He was continually in Paradise, and the devil understood that I wanted to make another world, because Adam was lord on earth, to rule over it and govern it." 4 "The devil is the evil spirit of the lower places. He made himself a fugitive from the heavens, since his name was Satanail, and so he became different from the angels; but although he was changed from the angels, his nature did not change his understanding of what is righteous and what is sinful." 5 "He understood his condemnation and the sin he had committed before, and so he conceived a plan against Adam. In this form he came in and deceived Eve, but did not touch

Adam." 6 "But I cursed ignorance. What I had blessed before I did not curse. I did not curse man, or the earth, or the other creatures, but man's evil fruit and his works."

Chapter 32

1 "I said to him, 'You are earth, and you will go into the earth from which I took you. I will not destroy you, but will send you back to where I took you from.'" 2 "Then I can receive you again at my second coming." 3 "I blessed all my creatures, visible and invisible. And Adam was five and a half hours in Paradise.[a]" 4 "I blessed the seventh day, which is the Sabbath, on which he rested from all his works."

Notes

- a (32:3) The sentence about Adam's five and a half hours is found in the longer recension; the shorter recension does not have it.

Chapter 33

1 "I also appointed the eighth day, that the eighth day should be the first created day after my work, and that the first seven should revolve in the form of the seventh thousand, and that at the beginning of the eighth thousand there should be a time of no counting, without end, with neither years nor months nor weeks nor days nor hours."[a] 2 "Now, Enoch, everything I have told you, everything you have understood, everything you have seen of heavenly things, everything you have seen on earth, and everything I have written in books by my great wisdom: all this I have devised and made, from the uppermost foundation to the lowest and to the end. I have no counselor and no heir for my creations." 3 "I am self-existing, not made by hands, and unchanging." 4 "My thought is my counselor; my wisdom and my word are made; my eyes watch all things, how they stand here and tremble in terror." 5 "If I turn my face away, then everything will be destroyed." 6 "Set your mind on this, Enoch, and know the one who is speaking to you, and take from there the books you yourself have written." 7 "I am giving you Samuil[b] and Raguil,[c] who led you up, and the books. Go down to earth and tell your sons all that I have told you and all that you have seen, from the lowest heaven up to my throne, and all the troops." 8 "For I made all the powers, and there is none

that resists me or does not subject himself to me. All subject themselves to my rule and work for my sole government." [9] "Give them the books written in your hand, and they will read them and know me as the creator of everything, and will understand that there is no other God but me." [10] "Let them pass the books of your handwriting on, children to children, generation to generation, nation to nation." [11] "And I will give you, Enoch, as your intercessor, the chief commander Michael, for the writings of your fathers, Adam, Seth, Enos, Cainan, Mahaleleel,[d] and your father Jared."

Notes

- a (33:1) Verses 1 and 2 of this chapter are missing from the shorter recension.
- b (33:7) "Samuil" is the name of an angel who is not otherwise known; it may be a form of Samuel or Semiel, but the meaning is uncertain.
- c (33:7) "Raguil" is Raguel (Hebrew *Re'u'el*), "friend of God"; in 1 Enoch 20:4 Raguel is the angel who takes vengeance on the world of the luminaries.
- d (33:11) These are the Septuagint-style forms of the names in Genesis 5: Adam ("man"); Seth (*Shet*, "appointed"); Enos (*Enosh*, "man"); Cainan (*Qenan*, perhaps "possession" or "smith"); Mahaleleel (*Mahalalel*, "praise of God"); and Jared (*Yered*, "descent").

Chapter 34

[1] "They have rejected my commandments and my yoke. Worthless seed has come up, not fearing God. They would not bow down to me but began to bow to empty gods, and denied my oneness. They have loaded the whole earth with lies, offenses, and abominable lust, with one another and with every other kind of unclean wickedness, too disgusting to relate." [2] "Therefore I will bring a flood on the earth and destroy all people, and the whole earth will crumble together into great darkness."

Chapter 35

[1] "Look, from their seed another generation will rise, much later, but many of them will be very greedy." [2] "The one who raises up that generation will show them the books of your writing and of your fathers. He must point out to them the guardianship of the world, to the faithful men and workers of my pleasure, who do not take my

name in vain." [3] "They will tell another generation, and those others, after reading, will be glorified afterward, more than the first."

Chapter 36

[1] "Now, Enoch, I give you thirty days to spend in your house. Tell your sons and all your household, so that all may hear from my face what you tell them, and that they may read and understand that there is no other God but me." [2] "Let them always keep my commandments, and begin to read and take in the books of your writing." [3] "After thirty days I will send my angel for you, and he will take you from the earth and from your sons to me."

Chapter 37

[1] Then the Lord called one of the older angels, terrible and menacing, and set him by my side. He looked white as snow, and his hands were like ice, with the look of a great frost, and he froze my face, because I could not bear the terror of the Lord, just as no one can bear the fire of a stove or the heat of the sun or the frost of the air. [2] The Lord said to me, "Enoch, if your face were not frozen here, no one would be able to look at your face."

Chapter 38

[1] The Lord said to the men who had first led me up, "Let Enoch go down to earth with you, and wait for him until the appointed day."[a] [2] They put me back in my bed at night. [3] Methuselah was waiting for me to come back, watching by my bed day and night. When he heard that I had come, he was filled with awe, and I told him, "Let all my household come together, so that I can tell them everything."

Notes

- a (38:1) The shorter recension omits this entire chapter.

Chapter 39

[1] "O my children, my beloved ones, listen to the warning of your father, as far as it agrees with the Lord's will." [2] "I have been allowed to come to you today and tell you, not from my own lips but from the lips of the Lord, everything that is and was, everything that is

happening now, and everything that will happen until the day of judgment." [3] "The Lord has let me come to you. So hear the words of my lips, the lips of a man made great for you; but I am one who has seen the Lord's face, which is like iron heated in a fire, throwing off sparks and burning." [4] "You look now at my eyes, the eyes of a man who is great in meaning for you, but I have seen the Lord's eyes, shining like the rays of the sun and filling the eyes of people with awe." [5] "You see now, my children, the right hand of a man who helps you, but I have seen the Lord's right hand, filling heaven as he helped me." [6] "You see the span of my work, like your own, but I have seen the Lord's limitless and perfect span, which has no end." [7] "You hear the words of my lips, as I heard the words of the Lord, like great thunder that never stops, with clouds hurled about." [8] "And now, my children, listen to the words of the father of the earth. How fearful and awful it is to come before the face of the ruler of the earth; how much more terrible and awful to come before the face of the ruler of heaven, the judge of the living and the dead, and of the heavenly troops. Who can endure that endless pain?"

Chapter 40

[1] "And now, my children, I know everything, because this is from the Lord's lips, and my own eyes have seen it, from beginning to end." [2] "I know everything, and I have written everything down in books: the heavens and their end and their fullness, and all the armies and their marches."[a] [3] "I have measured and described the stars, the great and countless multitude of them." [4] "What man has seen their turnings and their entrances? Not even the angels see their number, but I have written all their names." [5] "I measured the circle of the sun and measured its rays, and counted the hours. I also wrote down everything that moves over the earth. I wrote about the things that are fed, and about all seed, sown and unsown, that the earth produces, and all plants, every grass and every flower, and their sweet scents, and their names; and the dwelling places of the clouds and how they are made, and their wings, and how they carry rain and raindrops." [6] "I investigated everything, and I wrote down the road of the thunder and

the lightning. They showed me the keys and their guardians, their rising, and the way they go. Lightning is let out gently, by measure, on a chain, so that a heavy chain and violence do not hurl the angry clouds down and destroy everything on earth." [7] "I wrote down the storehouses of the snow and the vaults of the cold and frosty airs, and I watched their keeper of keys for the season. He fills the clouds with them, and does not run out of stores." [8] "I wrote down the resting places of the winds, and I watched and saw how their key-holders carry scales and measures. First they put the winds in one pan of the scales, and in the other the weights, and let them out by measure, skillfully, over the whole earth, so that by heavy breathing they do not make the earth shake." [9] "I measured the whole earth: its mountains and all its hills, fields, trees, stones, and rivers, everything that exists, I wrote down; the height from the earth to the seventh heaven, and downward to the very lowest hell, and the place of judgment, and the very great, open, weeping hell." [10] "I saw how the prisoners are in pain, waiting for the limitless judgment." [11] "I wrote down all who are being judged by the judge, and all their judgment and sentences, and all their works."

Notes

- a (40:2) In the shorter recension verses 2–7 of this chapter are missing, and the order of the whole chapter is quite different there.

Chapter 41

[1] "I saw all the forefathers from all time, with Adam and Eve. I sighed and burst into tears and spoke of the ruin of their dishonor." [2] "'Woe is me for my weakness and that of my forefathers,' I said, and I thought in my heart and said," [3] "'Blessed is the man who was never born, or who was born and will not sin before the Lord's face, so that he does not come into this place or bring on himself the yoke of this place.'"

Chapter 42

[1] "I saw the key-holders and the guards of the gates of hell standing like great serpents, with faces like lamps going out, with fiery eyes and sharp teeth. And I saw all the Lord's works, how right they are,

while the works of man are some good and some bad, and by their works those who lie wickedly are known."

Chapter 43

[1] "My children, I measured and wrote down every work, every measure, and every righteous judgment." [2] "As one year is more honored than another, so one man is more honored than another: some for great possessions, some for wisdom of heart, some for particular intelligence, some for cleverness, one for silence of lip, another for cleanness, one for strength, another for good looks, one for youth, another for quick wit, one for shape of body, another for good sense. Let it be heard everywhere: no one is better than the one who fears God. He will be more glorious in the time to come."

Chapter 44

[1] "The Lord made man with his own hands, in the likeness of his own face, and the Lord made him small and great." [2] "Whoever insults a ruler's face, and hates the Lord's face, has despised the Lord's face; and whoever vents anger on any man who has done no harm, the Lord's great anger will cut him down; whoever spits in a man's face to shame him will be cut down at the Lord's great judgment." [3] "Blessed is the man who does not turn his heart with malice against anyone, who helps the injured and the condemned, raises up the broken, and does charity for the needy. For on the day of the great judgment every weight, every measure, and every counterweight will be as in the market; that is, they are hung on scales and set out in the market, and each person will learn his own measure, and according to his measure will receive his reward."

Chapter 45

[1] "Whoever hurries to make offerings before the Lord's face, the Lord for his part will hurry that offering along by rewarding his work." [2] "But whoever multiplies the lamps before the Lord's face and does not judge truly, the Lord will not increase his treasure in the kingdom of the highest." [3] "When the Lord asks for bread, or candles, or the flesh of animals, or any other sacrifice, that is nothing. What God

asks for is pure hearts, and with all this he is only testing the heart of man."

Chapter 46

1 "Listen, my people, and take in the words of my lips." 2 "If anyone brings gifts to an earthly ruler but has disloyal thoughts in his heart, and the ruler knows it, will he not be angry with him, refuse his gifts, and hand him over to judgment?" 3 "Or if one man makes himself look good to another by a deceitful tongue but has evil in his heart, will the other not see through the treachery of his heart, and the first be condemned, since his untruth was plain to everyone?" 4 "And when the Lord sends a great light, then there will be judgment for the just and the unjust, and no one will escape notice there."

Chapter 47

1 "And now, my children, set your minds on this. Take careful note of the words of your father, all of which have come to you from the Lord's lips."[a] 2 "Take these books written in your father's hand and read them." 3 "For the books are many, and in them you will learn all the Lord's works, everything that has been from the beginning of creation, and will be until the end of time." 4 "If you keep my writings, you will not sin against the Lord; for there is no other besides the Lord, neither in heaven, nor on earth, nor in the very lowest places, nor in the one foundation." 5 "The Lord has placed the foundations in the unknown, and has spread out heavens, visible and invisible. He fixed the earth on the waters and made countless creatures. Who has counted the water and the foundation of what is unfixed, or the dust of the earth, or the sand of the sea, or the drops of rain, or the morning dew, or the breathings of the wind? Who has filled earth and sea, and the unbreakable winter?" 6 "I cut the stars out of fire and decorated the heaven and put it in their midst."

Notes

- a (47:1) The shorter recension omits this entire chapter.

Chapter 48

1 "The sun goes along the seven heavenly circles, which are the appointment of 182 thrones: it goes down on a short day, and again 182 on which it goes down on a long day. It has two thrones on which it rests, turning this way and that above the thrones of the months. From the seventeenth day of the month Tsivan (May–June)[a] it goes down to the month Thevan (December–January),[b] and from the seventeenth of Thevan it goes up." 2 "So it goes close to the earth, and then the earth is glad and makes its fruits grow. When it goes away, the earth is sad, and the trees and all fruits have no blossom." 3 "He measured all this with a good measurement of hours and fixed a measure by his wisdom, of the visible and the invisible." 4 "From the invisible he made all things visible, himself being invisible." 5 "So I make this known to you, my children. Distribute the books to your children, through all your generations, and among the nations that have the sense to fear God. Let them receive the books and come to love them more than any food or earthly sweets, and read them and devote themselves to them." 6 "Those who do not understand the Lord, who do not fear God, who do not accept but reject, who do not receive the books, a terrible judgment awaits them." 7 "Blessed is the man who will bear their yoke and drag it along, for he will be set free on the day of the great judgment."

Notes

- a (48:1) The shorter recension does not have this chapter. "Tsivan" is the Hebrew month Sivan, and "Thevan" is Tebet (Tevet), which here stand for the points where the sun's path turns at the summer and winter solstices; the Slavonic month names are not an exact calendar.
- b (48:1) In the Hebrew calendar Sivan falls in May–June and Tebet in December–January; the "seventeenth day" is given as in the Slavonic.

Chapter 49

1 "I swear to you, my children, but I do not swear by any oath, neither by heaven nor by earth, nor by any other creature that God made." 2 "The Lord said, 'There is no oath in me, and no injustice, but truth.'" 3 "If there is no truth in men, let them swear by the words 'Yes, yes,' or else 'No, no.'" 4 "And I swear to you, yes, yes, that no man has

ever been in his mother's womb without a place already prepared beforehand for the rest of that person's soul, and a measure fixed for how long it is intended that a man be tested in this world." [5] "Yes, children, do not deceive yourselves, for a place has been prepared beforehand for every human soul."

Chapter 50

[1] "I have put every man's work in writing, and no one born on earth can stay hidden, and his works cannot stay concealed." [2] "I see everything." [3] "So now, my children, spend the number of your days in patience and gentleness, so that you may inherit endless life." [4] "For the Lord's sake, endure every wound, every injury, every evil word and attack." [5] "If wrongs are done to you, do not pay them back to neighbor or enemy, because the Lord will pay them back for you and be your avenger on the day of the great judgment, so that there will be no taking of revenge here among men." [6] "Whoever among you spends gold or silver for his brother's sake will receive ample treasure in the world to come." [7] "Do not harm widows, orphans, or strangers, or God's wrath will come on you."

Chapter 51

[1] "Stretch out your hands to the poor as far as your strength allows." [2] "Do not hide your silver in the ground." [3] "Help the faithful man in his affliction, and affliction will not find you in your time of trouble." [4] "Every grievous and cruel yoke that comes on you, bear it all for the Lord's sake, and so you will find your reward in the day of judgment." [5] "It is good to go to the Lord's dwelling morning, noon, and evening, for the glory of your Creator." [6] "For every breathing thing glorifies him, and every creature, visible and invisible, gives him praise."

Chapter 52

[1] "Blessed is the man who opens his lips in praise of the God of hosts and praises the Lord with his heart." [2] "Cursed is every man who opens his lips to bring his neighbor into contempt and slander, because he brings God into contempt." [3] "Blessed is he who opens his lips to bless and praise God.[a]" [4] "Cursed before the Lord all the days of his life is he

who opens his lips to curse and abuse." [5] "Blessed is he who blesses all the Lord's works." [6] "Cursed is he who brings the Lord's creation into contempt." [7] "Blessed is he who looks down and lifts up the fallen." [8] "Cursed is he who looks for the destruction of what is not his and is eager for it." [9] "Blessed is he who keeps the foundations of his fathers firm from the beginning." [10] "Cursed is he who twists the decrees of his forefathers." [11] "Blessed is he who gives peace and love." [12] "Cursed is he who disturbs those who love their neighbors." [13] "Blessed is he who speaks with a humble tongue and heart to all." [14] "Cursed is he who speaks peace with his tongue while in his heart there is no peace but a sword." [15] "For all these things will be laid bare in the scales and in the books on the day of the great judgment."

Notes

- a (52:3) In the shorter recension verses 3 and 4 are missing.

Chapter 53

[1] "And now, my children, do not say, 'Our father is standing before God and is praying for our sins,' for there is no helper there for anyone who has sinned." [2] "You see how I wrote down all the works of every man before his creation, everything done among all men for all time. No one can tell or relate what I have written, because the Lord sees all the imaginings of man, how empty they are, where they lie in the storehouses of the heart." [3] "And now, my children, take careful note of all the words of your father that I am telling you, so that you do not regret it and say, 'Why did our father not tell us?'"

Chapter 54

[1] "At that time, because of not understanding this, let these books I have given you be an inheritance of your peace." [2] "Hand them to all who want them, and instruct them, so that they may see the Lord's very great and marvelous works."

Chapter 55

[1] "My children, look: the day of my appointed time has come near." [2] "The angels who will go with me are standing in front of me and urging me to leave you. They are standing here on earth, waiting for

what they have been told." [3] "For tomorrow I will go up to heaven, to the highest Jerusalem, to my eternal inheritance." [4] "So I tell you to do before the Lord's face everything that pleases him."

Chapter 56

[1] Methuselah[a] answered his father Enoch and said, "What would be pleasing to you, father, that I may do before you, so that you may bless our dwellings and your sons, and your people may be made glorious through you, and then you may depart as the Lord said?" [2] Enoch answered his son Methuselah and said, "Listen, child. From the time the Lord anointed me with the ointment of his glory, there has been no food in me, and my soul does not remember earthly enjoyment, nor do I want anything earthly."

Notes

- a (56:1) The Slavonic spells his name Mathosalam or Methosalam in these chapters, which is the same Methuselah named in chapter 1.

Chapter 57

[1] "My child Methuselah, call all your brothers and all your household and the elders of the people, so that I may speak to them and depart, as is planned for me." [2] Methuselah hurried and called his brothers, Regim, Riman, Uchan, Chermion,[a] and Gaidad, and all the elders of the people before his father Enoch. Enoch blessed them and said to them:

Notes

- a (57:2) The names Riman, Uchan, and Chermion appear only in these Slavonic copies. Their meanings are unknown. For Regim and Gaidad, see the note at chapter 1.

Chapter 58

[1] "Listen to me today, my children." [2] "In those days, when the Lord came down to the earth for Adam's sake and visited all his creatures, which he himself had made, after all these he made Adam. The Lord called all the beasts of the earth, all the reptiles, and all the birds that fly in the air, and brought them all before our father Adam." [3] "Adam gave names to all the living things on earth." [4] "The Lord appointed

him ruler over all and put everything under his hands. He made them mute and dull, so that man could command them and they would be subject and obedient to him." [5] "In the same way the Lord made every man lord over all his possessions." [6] "The Lord will not judge a single beast's soul for man's sake, but he will judge the souls of men in the matter of their beasts in this world; for men have a special place." [7] "And just as every human soul is counted by number, so the beasts will not perish, nor any of the souls of the beasts that the Lord made, until the great judgment, and they will accuse man if he has fed them badly."

Chapter 59

[1] "Whoever defiles the soul of beasts defiles his own soul." [2] "For man brings clean animals to make a sacrifice for sin, so that he may have healing for his soul." [3] "If they bring clean animals and birds for sacrifice, man has healing; he heals his soul.[a]" [4] "Everything is given to you for food. Bind the animal by its four feet; that is, make the healing complete, and heal your soul." [5] "But whoever kills a beast without wounds kills his own soul and defiles his own flesh." [6] "And he who does any harm at all to any beast, in secret, is practicing evil and defiles his own soul."

Notes

- a (59:3) The shorter recension does not have verses 3 to 5 of this chapter.

Chapter 60

[1] "He who brings about the killing of a human soul kills his own soul and kills his own body, and there is no healing for him for all time." [2] "He who sets a snare for a man will be caught in it himself, and there is no healing for him for all time.[a]" [3] "He who puts a man into any container, his punishment will not be missing at the great judgment for all time." [4] "He who works crookedly or speaks evil against any soul will not obtain justice for himself for all time."

Notes

- a (60:2) The shorter recension lacks most of this chapter after verse 1; the longer text is followed here.

Chapter 61

[1] “And now, my children, keep your hearts from every injustice that the Lord hates. Just as a man asks God for something for his own soul, so let him do for every living soul. I know everything: in the great time to come, a great inheritance is prepared for men, good for the good and bad for the bad, without number.” [2] “Blessed are those who enter the good houses, for in the bad houses there is no peace and no return from them.” [3] “Listen, my children, small and great! When a man puts a good thought in his heart and brings gifts from his labors before the Lord’s face, but his hands did not make them, then the Lord will turn his face away from the labor of that man’s hand, and the man will not find the labor of his hands.” [4] “And if his hands made it, but his heart grumbles, and his heart does not stop grumbling constantly, he has no advantage.”

Chapter 62

[1] “Blessed is the man who, in his patience, brings his gifts with faith before the Lord’s face, because he will find forgiveness of sins.” [2] “But if he takes back his words before the time, there is no repentance for him; and if the time passes and he does not do of his own will what he promised, there is no repentance after death.” [3] “For every work a man does before the time is all deceit before men and sin before God.”

Chapter 63

[1] “When a man clothes the naked and feeds the hungry, he will find a reward from God.” [2] “But if his heart grumbles, he commits a double evil: ruin of himself and of what he gives; and for him there will be no finding of reward because of it.” [3] “If his own heart is full of his own food and his own flesh, clothed in his own clothing, he commits contempt, and will lose all the reward for his endurance of poverty, and will not find a reward for his good deeds.” [4] “Every proud and boastful man is hateful to the Lord, and so is every false speech clothed in untruth. It will be cut with the blade of the sword of death, thrown into the fire, and burn for all time.”

Chapter 64

1 When Enoch had said these words to his sons, all the people, far
and near, heard that the Lord was calling Enoch. They took counsel
together: 2 "Let us go and kiss Enoch." Two thousand men came
together and came to the place Achuzan,[a] where Enoch was with his
sons. 3 The elders of the people, the whole assembly, came and bowed
down and began to kiss Enoch, and said to him, 4 "Our father Enoch,
may you be blessed by the Lord, the eternal ruler. And now bless your
sons and all the people, so that we may be glorified today before your
face." 5 "For you will be glorified before the Lord's face for all time,
since the Lord chose you rather than all men on earth, and appointed
you writer of all his creation, visible and invisible, and redeemer of
the sins of man, and helper of your household."

Notes

- a (64:2) "Achuzan" is the Slavonic name of the place, and its location and meaning are unknown. It may come from the Hebrew word *achuzzah* ("possession"), but that is only a guess.

Chapter 65

1 Enoch answered all his people, saying, "Listen, my children. Before
all creatures were made, the Lord made the visible and the invisible
things." 2 "And however much time there was and passed by, under-
stand that after all that he made man in the likeness of his own
form, and put into him eyes to see, ears to hear, a heart to reflect,
and a mind to deliberate with." 3 "The Lord saw all the works of
man, and made all his creatures, and divided time. From time he
fixed the years, from the years he appointed the months, from the
months he appointed the days, and of the days he appointed seven." 4
"In these he appointed the hours and measured them out exactly, so
that man might reflect on time and count years, months, and hours,
their alternation, beginning, and end, and that he might count his
own life from the beginning until death, and reflect on his sin and
write down his work, bad and good. For no work is hidden before the
Lord, so that every man may know his works and never break any of
his commandments, and keep my writing from generation to gener-

ation." [5] "When all creation, visible and invisible, as the Lord made it, comes to its end, then every man goes to the great judgment, and then all time will perish, and the years, and from then on there will be no months, days, or hours. They will be joined together and will not be counted." [6] "There will be one age, and all the righteous who escape the Lord's great judgment will be gathered into the great age. For the righteous the great age will begin, and they will live forever, and then there will be among them no toil, sickness, humiliation, anxiety, need, brutality, night, or darkness, but great light." [7] "They will have a great indestructible wall, and a Paradise bright and incorruptible, eternal; for all corruptible, mortal things will pass away, and there will be eternal life."

Chapter 66

[1] "And now, my children, keep your souls from all injustice, such as the Lord hates." [2] "Walk before his face with fear and trembling, and serve him alone." [3] "Bow down to the true God, not to mute idols, but bow down to his likeness, and bring all just offerings before the Lord's face. The Lord hates what is unjust." [4] "For the Lord sees everything. When a man takes thought in his heart, then he advises the minds, and every thought is always before the Lord, who made the earth firm and put all creatures on it." [5] "If you look to heaven, the Lord is there. If you think of the deep of the sea and everything under the earth, the Lord is there." [6] "For the Lord made all things. Do not bow down to things made by man, leaving the Lord of all creation, because no work can stay hidden before the Lord's face." [7] "Walk, my children, in long-suffering, in gentleness, in honesty, in provocation, in grief, in faith and in truth, in reliance on promises, in illness, in abuse, in wounds, in temptation, in nakedness, in need, loving one another, until you go out from this age of ills, so that you become heirs of endless time." [8] "Blessed are the righteous who will escape the great judgment, for they will shine more than the sun, sevenfold. For in this world a seventh part is taken off from everything: light, darkness, food, enjoyment, sorrow, Paradise, torture, fire, frost, and

other things. He put everything down in writing, so that you might read and understand."

Chapter 67

1 When Enoch had finished talking to the people, the Lord sent darkness over the earth. There was darkness, and it covered those men standing with Enoch, and they took Enoch up into the highest heaven, where the Lord is. He received him and set him before his face, and the darkness went away from the earth, and light came again. 2 The people saw this but did not understand how Enoch had been taken. They glorified God and found a scroll in which was traced "The Invisible God." And all went to their homes.

Chapter 68

1 Enoch was born on the sixth day of the month Tsivan (May–June)[a] and lived 365 years. 2 He was taken up to heaven on the first day of the month Tsivan (May–June) and stayed in heaven sixty days. 3 He wrote all these signs of all creation, which the Lord made, and wrote 366 books, and handed them over to his sons. He stayed on earth thirty days and was taken up to heaven again on the sixth day of the month Tsivan (May–June), on the very day and hour when he was born. 4 As every man's nature in this life is dark, so are his conception, birth, and departure from this life. 5 At whatever hour he was conceived, at that hour he was born, and at that hour he died. 6 Methuselah and his brothers, all the sons of Enoch, hurried and built an altar at the place called Achuzan, from where Enoch had been taken up to heaven. 7 They took sacrificial oxen and called all the people together and offered the sacrifice before the Lord's face. 8 All the people, the elders of the people, and the whole assembly came to the feast and brought gifts to the sons of Enoch. 9 They held a great feast, rejoicing and making merry for three days, praising God, who had given them such a sign through Enoch, who had found favor with him; and they were to pass it on to their sons from generation to generation, from age to age. 10 Amen.

Notes

- a (68:1) “Tsivan” is the Hebrew month Sivan, which falls in May–June; the Slavonic gives the days of the month only.

2 Baruch

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

The coming destruction of Jerusalem announced to Baruch

1 In the twenty-fifth year of Jeconiah,[a] king of Judah[b], the word of
the Lord came to Baruch[c] son of Neriah.[d] It said to him, 2 "Do you
see everything these people are doing to Me? The wrongs of these
two tribes that were left are worse than the wrongs of the ten tribes
that were carried off into exile. 3 The earlier tribes were pushed into
sin by their kings, but these two have pushed and pressed their own
kings to sin. 4 So I am bringing disaster on this city. For a time it will
be taken out of My sight, and I will scatter this people among the
nations so that they may do those nations good. My people will be
disciplined, and a time will come when they will long for the good
days they once had."

Notes

- a (1:1) "Jeconiah" is another name for King Jehoiachin; the Hebrew form *Yekonyah* means "Yahweh will establish." He was taken to Babylon in 597 BC, and the book dates its opening scene by his reign, though the story itself is set later, at the fall of Jerusalem in 587/586 BC.
- b (1:1) "Judah" (Hebrew *Yehudah*) is linked in Genesis 29 with "praise." It names the southern kingdom.
- c (1:1) "Baruch" (Hebrew *Barukh*) means "blessed." He is the scribe who wrote down Jeremiah's words in the book of Jeremiah.
- d (1:1) "Neriah" (Hebrew *Neriyyah*) means "lamp of Yahweh."

Chapter 2

1 "I have told you this so that you can tell Jeremiah[a] and everyone like
you to leave this city. 2 For your works are like a solid pillar under
this city, and your prayers like a strong wall around it."

Notes

- a (2:1) "Jeremiah" (Hebrew *Yirmeyahu*) is traditionally explained as "Yahweh raises up" or "Yahweh loosens."

Chapter 3

1 I answered, "O Lord, my Lord, did I come into the world only to
watch my mother[a] suffer? No, my Lord! 2 If I have found favor with
You, take my spirit first, so that I may go to my fathers and not see
my mother destroyed. 3 Two things press hard on me: I cannot stand
against You, and my soul cannot bear to see my mother suffer. 4 But
let me say one thing before You, Lord. 5 What will happen after all
this? If You destroy Your city and hand over Your land to those who
hate us, how will the name of Israel[b] ever be remembered again? 6
Who will sing Your praises? To whom will the teaching of Your law
be explained? Will the world go back to what it was before creation,
and the age return to the silence of the beginning? Will the whole
multitude of souls be swept away and the human race never be named
again? And where is everything You promised about us?"

Notes

- a (3:1) The city of Jerusalem, called here "my mother," as Zion is often pictured as a mother in the Hebrew prophets.
- b (3:5) "Israel" (Hebrew *Yisrael*) is explained in Genesis 32 as "he struggles with God."

Chapter 4

The heavenly Jerusalem

1 The Lord said to me, "This city will be handed over for a time. The
people will be disciplined for a time. But the world will not be given
over to oblivion. 2 Do you think this is the city of which I said, 'I have
carved you on the palms of My hands'? 3 The building that stands
among you now is not the one that is kept with Me, the one that was
prepared long ago, from the moment I planned to make Paradise, and
that I showed to Adam[a] before he sinned. When he disobeyed the
command, it was taken from him, just as Paradise was. 4 Afterward I
showed it to My servant Abraham[b], by night, among the halves of the
sacrificed animals. 5 And again I showed it to Moses[c] on Mount Sinai,
when I showed him the pattern of the tent and all its furnishings. 6
Now it is kept safe with Me, like Paradise. 7 So go, and do what I have
commanded you."

Notes

- a (4:3) “Adam” (Hebrew *adam*) means “human being,” from the word for the ground, *adamah*.
- b (4:4) “Abraham” (Hebrew *Avraham*) is explained in Genesis 17 as “father of a multitude.”
- c (4:5) “Moses” (Hebrew *Mosheh*) is linked in Exodus 2 with “drawing out.”

Chapter 5

Baruch’s complaint, and God’s reassurance

1 I answered, “So I am to grieve over Zion[a]. Your enemies will come to
this place and defile Your sanctuary, carry Your inheritance off into
captivity, and lord it over those You have loved. Then they will go
back to the home of their idols and boast in front of them. What will
You do for Your great name?” 2 The Lord said to me, “My name and
My glory last forever, and My judgment will take its own course in its
own time. 3 You will see with your own eyes that the enemy will not
overthrow Zion or burn Jerusalem[b]. They will only serve for a while
as the Judge’s instruments. 4 But go and do everything I have told
you.” 5 So I went and took Jeremiah, Adu,[c] Seraiah,[d] Jabish,[e] Gedaliah,[f]
and all the honored men of the people. I led them to the Kidron[g] valley
and told them everything I had been told. 6 They raised their voices
and all wept. 7 We sat there and fasted until evening.

Notes

- a (5:1) “Zion” (Hebrew *Tsiyyon*) is the hill of Jerusalem on which the temple stood, and a poetic name for the city and its people.
- b (5:3) “Jerusalem” (Hebrew *Yerushalayim*) is often explained as “foundation of peace” or “city of peace.”
- c (5:5) “Adu” appears only here and may be a copyist’s form of another name; it is not found in the Bible. It is kept as written.
- d (5:5) “Seraiah” (Hebrew *Serayah*) means “Yahweh has striven” or “Yahweh rules.”
- e (5:5) “Jabish” is not a name known from the Bible; the Hebrew *Yavesh* is related to “dry,” as in Jabesh-gilead. It is kept as written.
- f (5:5) “Gedaliah” (Hebrew *Gedalyahu*) means “Yahweh is great.” A Gedaliah was appointed governor of Judah after the fall of Jerusalem (Jeremiah 40).
- g (5:5) The “Kidron” (Hebrew *Qidron*), probably “dark” or “turbid,” is the valley east of Jerusalem between the city and the Mount of Olives.

Chapter 6

The Chaldeans invade; the sacred vessels are hidden

1 The next day the army of the Chaldeans[a] surrounded the city. In the
evening I, Baruch, left the people, went out, and stood beside the oak.
2 I was grieving over Zion and mourning the captivity that had come
upon the people. 3 Suddenly a strong spirit lifted me and carried me
up over the wall of Jerusalem. 4 I looked, and there were four angels
standing at the four corners of the city, each holding a blazing torch.
5 Another angel began to come down from heaven. He said to them,
"Hold your lamps, and do not light them until I tell you. 6 I have been
sent first, to speak a word to the earth and to put into it what the Lord,
the Most High, has ordered me to give." 7 I saw him go down into the
Holy of Holies and take from it the veil, the holy ark, the mercy seat,
the two tablets, the holy garments of the priests, the altar of incense,
the forty-eight precious stones with which the priest was adorned,
and all the holy furnishings of the tent. 8 He called to the earth in
a loud voice, "Earth, earth, earth, hear the word of the mighty God!
Receive what I entrust to you, and guard it until the last times, so that
when you are ordered you may give it back, and strangers may not
take possession of it. 9 For the time is coming when Jerusalem too will
be handed over for a while, until it is said that she is restored forever."
10 Then the earth opened its mouth and swallowed them.

Notes

- a (6:1) "Chaldeans" (Hebrew *Kasdim*) is the Bible's name for the Babylonians.

Chapter 7

1 After this I heard that angel say to the angels holding the lamps,
"Now destroy the wall and throw it down to its foundations, so that
the enemy cannot boast and say, 'We have thrown down the wall of
Zion and burned the place of the mighty God.'" 2 And they took the
place where I had been standing.

Chapter 8

1 The angels did as he had ordered. When they had broken down
the corners of the walls, a voice was heard from inside the temple

after the wall had fallen. It said, [2] "Come in, you enemies; come, you adversaries! The One who guarded the house has left it." [3] Then I, Baruch, went away. [4] After this the Chaldean army entered, seized the house and everything around it, led the people off as captives, killed some of them, and bound King Zedekiah[a] and sent him to the king of Babylon[b].

Notes

- a (8:4) "Zedekiah" (Hebrew *Tsidqiyyahu*) means "Yahweh is my righteousness." He was the last king of Judah.
- b (8:4) "Babylon" (Hebrew *Bavel*) is linked in Genesis 11 with "confusion," from the verb *balal*. The Babylonians themselves understood it as "gate of God."

Chapter 9

A seven-day fast; Jeremiah goes with the exiles

[1] Then I, Baruch, came with Jeremiah, whose heart was found pure of sin and who had not been taken when the city was seized. [2] We tore our clothes, wept, mourned, and fasted for seven days.

Chapter 10

[1] After seven days the word of God came to me and said, [2] "Tell Jeremiah to go and support the people in their captivity in Babylon. But you stay here among the ruins of Zion, and after these days I will show you what will happen at the end of days." [3] I told Jeremiah as the Lord had commanded. [4] He left with the people. [5] But I, Baruch, went back and sat in front of the gates of the temple, and I sang this lament over Zion: [6] "Blessed is the one who was never born, or the one who was born and has died. [7] But for us who live, woe! We see Zion's sufferings and what has happened to Jerusalem. [8] I will call the sirens from the sea. Come, Lilin,[a] from the desert, and you Shedim[b] and dragons from the forests. Wake up, tie up your clothes for mourning, take up the dirges with me, and lament with me. [9] Farmers, do not sow again. Earth, why give your harvest of fruit? Keep the sweet things of your food within you. [10] And you, vine, why give wine any more? No offering will ever again be made from you in Zion, and firstfruits will no longer be brought. [11] Heavens, hold back your dew and do not open the storehouses of rain. [12] Sun, hold back the light of your rays; moon,

put out the multitude of your light. For why should light rise again where the light of Zion is darkened? [13] Bridegrooms, do not go in. Brides, do not put on wreaths. Women, do not pray to bear children. [14] For the childless will be happier than anyone, and those with no sons will be glad, and those with sons will be in anguish. [15] Why should they give birth in pain, only to bury in grief? [16] Why should the human race bear sons again, or why should the line of their kind be named again, when this mother lies desolate and her sons are led off into captivity? [17] From now on, do not speak of beauty and do not talk of grace. [18] Priests, take the keys of the sanctuary and throw them high into heaven. Give them to the Lord and say, "Guard Your own house, for we have turned out to be false stewards." [19] And you, virgins who weave fine linen and silk with gold from Ophir,[c] take all these things quickly and throw them into the fire, so that the fire may carry them to the One who made them, and the flame may send them to the One who created them, and the enemy may not take them.

Notes

- a (10:8) The Syriac has "Lilin," feminine night-creatures of Jewish folklore, related to the Hebrew *lilith* ("night creature") in Isaiah 34:14.
- b (10:8) "Shedim" (Hebrew *shedim*) are demons or spirits; the word occurs in Deuteronomy 32:17 and Psalm 106:37.
- c (10:19) "Ophir" is a land famous for its gold (1 Kings 9); its location is unknown, and some place it in southern Arabia, East Africa, or India. The name is kept as written.

Chapter 11

[1] "I also say this against you, Babylon. If you had prospered while Zion lived in her glory, our grief would still have been great, to see you made equal to Zion. [2] But now the grief is endless and the mourning has no measure, for you flourish and Zion is desolate. [3] Who will judge these things? To whom shall we bring our complaint about what has happened to us? Lord, how have You endured it? [4] Our fathers went to rest without grief, and the righteous sleep in the earth in peace. [5] They did not know this anguish, and they had not heard what has happened to us. [6] If only you had ears, earth, and a heart, dust, so

that you could go and tell Sheol,[a] and say to the dead, 7 'You are more blessed than we who live.'"

Notes

- a (11:6) "Sheol" is the Hebrew name for the place of the dead.

Chapter 12

1 "But I will say what I think, and I will speak against you, land, that now prospers. 2 The noonday sun does not burn all the time, and its rays do not always give light. 3 Do not expect to stay prosperous and joyful forever, and do not be so proud and boastful. 4 For in its own season the wrath of God will surely wake against you, though now, in His patience, it is held back as if by reins." 5 When I had said all this, I fasted for seven days.

Chapter 13

A second fast; judgment on the nations

1 After this I, Baruch, was standing on Mount Zion, and a voice came from on high and said to me, 2 "Stand on your feet, Baruch, and hear the word of the mighty God. 3 You were stunned at what has happened to Zion, and for that very reason you will be kept safe until the end of the times, to serve as a witness. 4 Then, if those prosperous cities ever say, 5 'Why has the mighty God brought this punishment on us?' you and those like you who have seen this disaster will tell them, 'This is the evil, and this is the punishment, that is coming on you and your people at its appointed time, so that the nations may be thoroughly struck down.' 6 Then they will be in anguish. 7 And if they say at that time, 8 'How long?' you will tell them, 'You who drank the strained wine, now drink its dregs as well. That is the judgment of the Most High, who shows no favoritism.' 9 For that reason He had no mercy on His own sons in earlier times, but treated them as enemies because they sinned. 10 So they were disciplined, in order to be made holy. 11 But now, you peoples and nations, you are guilty, because you have always trampled the earth and misused creation. 12 For I have always done you good, and you have always been ungrateful for it."

Chapter 14

Why the righteous perish; God's answer

1 I answered, "You have shown me how the times will run and what
will come after them, and You have told me that the punishment You
have spoken of will fall on the nations. 2 Now I know that those who
have sinned are many, and they lived in comfort and then left the
world. But few nations will be left in those times to hear the words
You have spoken. 3 What good is it to us, or what could be worse than
what we have already seen happen to us, that we should wait to see
it? 4 But let me speak again before You. 5 What have they gained who
knew You and did not walk in emptiness like the other nations, who
never said to the dead, 'Give us life,' but always feared You and never
left Your ways? 6 Yet they have been swept away, and You have shown
Zion no mercy on their account. 7 If others did evil, it was for Zion's
sake that she should have been forgiven, on account of the works
of those who did good, and she should not have been overwhelmed
on account of the works of those who did wrong. 8 But who, O Lord,
my Lord, can grasp Your judgment? Who can search out the depth of
Your way? Who can think through the weight of Your path? 9 Who
can take in Your unfathomable counsel? Which of those who are born
has ever found the beginning or the end of Your wisdom? 10 For we
have all been made like a breath. 11 As breath goes up unasked and
dies away again, so it is with human nature. We do not leave by our
own will, and we do not know what will happen to us at the end.
12 The righteous rightly look forward to the end, and they leave this
dwelling without fear, because they have a store of works laid up with
You in treasuries. 13 So they leave this world without fear, and with
joy they hope to receive the world You have promised them. 14 But
we are in trouble: we are shamefully treated now, and in that time
we look ahead to nothing but disasters. 15 You know exactly what You
have done through Your servants, but we cannot understand what is
good, as You, our Creator, do. 16 Let me speak once more before You, O
Lord, my Lord. 17 Long ago, when there was no world with people in it,
You planned and spoke by a word, and at once the works of creation
stood before You. 18 You said that You would make humankind the

steward of Your works, so that it might be known that humankind was not made for the sake of the world, but the world for the sake of humankind. 19 Now I see that the world made for our sake is still here, but we, for whom it was made, are going away."

Chapter 15

1 The Lord answered me, "You are right to be amazed at the departure of human beings, but you have not judged well the evils that come on those who sin. 2 As for what you said, that the righteous are taken away while the wicked prosper, 3 and what you said, that a man does not know Your judgment, 4 listen, and I will speak to you; pay attention, and I will let you hear My words. 5 A man would not have understood My judgment rightly unless he had received the law and I had taught him understanding. 6 But he broke it knowingly, and for that very reason, because he knew, he will be tormented. 7 As for what you said about the righteous, that this world came into being on their account, so also the world to come will come on their account. 8 For to them this world is a struggle and a labor with much trouble, and the world that is coming is a crown with great glory."

Chapter 16

1 I answered, "O Lord, my Lord, the years of this time are few and bad. Who can win in his short time what has no measure?"

Chapter 17

1 The Lord answered me, "With the Most High, time and a few years are not counted. 2 What good did it do Adam that he lived nine hundred and thirty years and still broke what he was told? His long life did not help him. It brought death and cut short the years of all who were born from him. And what did Moses lose by living only a hundred and twenty years? Because he stayed under the One who formed him, he brought the law to the seed of Jacob[a] and lit a lamp for the nation of Israel."

Notes

- a (17:2) "Jacob" (Hebrew *Yaaqov*) is explained as "he grasps the heel" or "he supplants."

Chapter 18

1 I answered, “The one who lit the lamp took from the light, and few
have followed him. But the many he lit it for took from the darkness
of Adam and did not rejoice in the light of the lamp.”

Chapter 19

1 He answered me, “At that time He set a covenant before them and
said, ‘See, I have put before you life and death.’ And He called heaven
and earth to witness against them. 2 For He knew that His own time
was short, but that heaven and earth last forever. 3 After his death they
sinned and broke the covenant, though they knew they had the law to
correct them, and the light in which nothing could go wrong, and the
heavenly spheres that testify, and Me. 4 About everything that exists, I
am the one who judges. Do not argue about these things in your soul,
and do not torment yourself over what has already happened. 5 What
now needs to be weighed is the end of the time, whether of business,
of prosperity, or of shame, and not its beginning. 6 If a man does well
at the start and is treated shamefully in his old age, he forgets all the
good he had. 7 And if a man is treated shamefully at the start and
does well at the end, he does not remember his earlier mistreatment.
8 Listen again. Suppose each person did well for all that time, from
the day death was decreed against those who disobey, and then was
destroyed at the end. Everything would have been in vain.”

Chapter 20

Zion has been taken away to hasten the judgment

1 “So see, the days are coming, and the times will move faster than
before, and the seasons will hurry along faster than those that are
past, and the years will go by faster than the present ones. 2 That
is why I have now taken Zion away, so that I may visit the world
sooner, in its season. 3 Now hold on to everything I command you,
and seal it in the hidden places of your mind. 4 Then I will show you
the judgment of My power and My ways that cannot be searched out.
5 Go and make yourself holy for seven days. Eat no bread, drink no
water, and speak to no one. 6 After that, come to that place, and I will

reveal Myself to you and speak true things with you. I will give you commands about how the times run, for they are coming and will not wait."

Chapter 21

Baruch's prayer, and God's answer

1 I went there and sat in the Kidron valley in an earth cave, and I made my soul holy. I ate no bread, yet I was not hungry. I drank no water, yet I was not thirsty. I stayed there until the seventh day, as He had commanded me. 2 Then I came to the place where He had spoken with me. 3 At sunset my soul was deep in thought, and I began to speak in the presence of the Mighty One. I said, 4 "You who made the earth, hear me! You fixed the sky by a word and set the height of heaven firm by Your spirit. From the beginning You called what did not yet exist, and it obeys You. 5 You commanded the air with a nod, and You see what is yet to be as clearly as what You are doing now. 6 You rule with great purpose the hosts that stand before You, and the countless holy beings that You made from the beginning, made of flame and fire, who stand around Your throne; You rule them with fierce force. 7 It belongs to You alone to do at once whatever You wish. 8 You make the raindrops fall on the earth by number, and You alone know the end of the times before they come. Look kindly on my prayer. 9 For You alone can sustain all who are, those who have passed away and those who are yet to be, those who sin and those who are righteous, as living beings who cannot be fully known. 10 For You alone live forever, beyond all searching out, and You know the number of mankind. 11 And if in time many have sinned, others, not a few, have been righteous. 12 You know where You keep the end of those who sinned and the final reward of those who were righteous. 13 For if there were only this life, which belongs to everyone, nothing could be more bitter. 14 What use is strength that turns to sickness, or a full table that turns to famine, or beauty that turns to ugliness? 15 For human nature is always changing. 16 What we were before, we no longer are; and what we are now, we will not stay. 17 If an end had not been prepared for all, their beginning would have been pointless. 18

But tell me about everything that comes from You, and shed light on everything I ask You. 19 How long will what decays go on? How long will mortals prosper? And until when will those who sin in the world be stained with so much wickedness? 20 Command it in mercy and carry out everything You said You would bring, so that Your power may be known to those who think Your patience is weakness. 21 Show those who do not know that all that has happened to us and to our city until now has been within the patience of Your power, because for Your name's sake You called us a beloved people. 22 Put an end to death from now on. 23 Rebuke the angel of death, and let Your glory appear, and let the might of Your beauty be known. Let Sheol be sealed so that from now on it takes in no more dead, and let the storehouses of souls give back those shut up in them. 24 For many years have been like desolate ones since the days of Abraham, Isaac[a], Jacob, and all who are like them, who sleep in the earth, those for whose sake You said You created the world. 25 Now show Your glory quickly, and do not put off what You promised." 26 When I finished the words of this prayer, I was very weak.

Notes

- a (21:24) "Isaac" (Hebrew *Yitschaq*) means "he laughs."

Chapter 22

1 After this, the heavens opened, and I saw, and power was given to me, and a voice from on high said to me, 2 "Baruch, Baruch, why are you troubled? 3 If someone sets out on a road and does not finish it, or leaves by sea and does not reach harbor, can he be comforted? 4 If someone promises a gift to another and does not give it, is that not robbery? 5 If someone sows a field and does not reap its fruit in season, does he not lose everything? 6 If someone plants a plant and it does not grow until its time, can the one who planted it expect fruit from it? 7 If a woman conceives and gives birth too early, does she not surely kill her child? 8 If someone builds a house and does not roof it and finish it, can it be called a house? Tell Me that first."

Chapter 23

1 I answered, “Surely not, O Lord, my Lord.” 2 He answered me, “Then
why are you troubled about what you do not know, and uneasy about
things of which you are ignorant? 3 Just as you have not forgotten the
people who now live and those who have passed away, so I remember
those who are appointed to come. 4 When Adam sinned and death
was decreed against all who would be born, the number of those
to be born was counted, and a place was prepared for that number,
where the living might live and the dead might be kept. 5 Before that
number is complete, the creature will not live again, for My Spirit
is the creator of life, and Sheol will receive the dead. 6 And again, it
is given to you to hear what will come after these times. 7 For My
redemption has truly come near; it is not far off as it was before.”

Chapter 24

The coming judgment

1 “See, the days are coming when the books will be opened in which
the sins of all who have sinned are written, and also the storehouses
in which the righteousness of all who have been righteous in creation
is gathered. 2 At that time you will see, and many with you, the
patience of the Most High, which has lasted through all generations,
patient toward all who are born, those who sin and those who are
righteous alike.” 3 I answered, “But, Lord, no one knows the number
of what has passed or of what is still to come. 4 I know indeed what
has happened to us, but what will happen to our enemies I do not
know, or when You will visit Your works.”

Chapter 25

The sign of the coming judgment

1 He answered me, “You too will be kept until that time, until the sign
that the Most High will give to the people of the earth at the end
of days. 2 This will be the sign. 3 When a stupor takes hold of the
people of the earth and they fall into many troubles, and then again
into great torments, 4 they will say in their thoughts, because of all

their suffering, ‘The Mighty One no longer remembers the earth.’ Yes, when they give up hope, then the time will wake.”

Chapter 26

[1] I answered, “Will that tribulation last a long time? Will that hardship go on for many years?”

Chapter 27

The twelve woes, the Messiah, and the temporary Messianic kingdom

[1] He answered me, “That time is divided into twelve parts, and each is kept for what is assigned to it. [2] In the first part there will be the beginning of unrest. [3] In the second part, the killing of great men. [4] In the third part, the fall of many through death. [5] In the fourth part, the sending of the sword. [6] In the fifth part, famine and the holding back of rain. [7] In the sixth part, earthquakes and terrors. [8] The seventh part is missing in the Syriac text.[a] [9] In the eighth part, a crowd of ghosts and attacks by the Shedim. [10] In the ninth part, the falling of fire. [11] In the tenth part, plunder and heavy oppression. [12] In the eleventh part, wickedness and sexual wrongdoing. [13] In the twelfth part, confusion from the mixing together of all the things just named. [14] These parts of that time are held in reserve, and they will mingle with one another and serve one another. [15] Some will leave out part of their own and take from others, and some will finish their own and others’ as well, so that those living on the earth in those days will not understand that this is the end of the times.”

Notes

- a (27:8) The seventh part is missing in the Syriac manuscript; nothing is supplied here, and the list resumes at the eighth.

Chapter 28

[1] “Even so, whoever understands will be wise then. [2] The measure and count of that time is two parts of a week of seven weeks.” [3] I answered, “It is good for a man to come and see, but better that he not come, lest he fall. [4] But I will also say this. [5] Will someone who is incorruptible look down on things that are corruptible, and on whatever happens

to them, so that he looks only at what is not corruptible? 6 But if, Lord, what You have told me will surely come to pass, then show me this as well, if I have found favor with You. 7 Will these things take place in one place, or in one part of the earth, or will the whole earth experience them?"

Chapter 29

1 He answered me, "Whatever will happen then will happen to the whole earth, so all who live will experience it. 2 At that time I will protect only those who are found in this land in those very days. 3 When everything that was to happen in those parts has been done, the Messiah will begin to be revealed. 4 Behemoth[a] will be revealed from his place, and Leviathan[b] will rise from the sea, the two great monsters I made on the fifth day of creation and have kept until that time. Then they will be food for all who are left. 5 The earth will yield its fruit ten-thousandfold. Each vine will have a thousand branches, each branch will bear a thousand clusters, each cluster a thousand grapes, and each grape will give a cor[c] of wine, about 55 gallons. 6 Those who were hungry will rejoice, and every day they will see marvels. 7 Winds will go out from Me every morning to bring the fragrance of spice-bearing fruits, and at the end of each day, clouds that let fall the dew of health. 8 At that same time the storehouse of manna will again come down from on high, and they will eat of it in those years, because these are the ones who have come to the end of the age."

Notes

- a (29:4) "Behemoth" (Hebrew *behemot*) is the great land beast of Job 40:15-24.
- b (29:4) "Leviathan" (Hebrew *livyatan*) is the sea monster of Job 41 and Psalm 74:14.
- c (29:5) The Syriac has *cor*, a Hebrew dry and liquid measure (*kor*). It is usually reckoned at roughly 45 to 60 gallons (170 to 230 liters); the figure given in the text is an approximation.

Chapter 30

The resurrection

1 “After this, when the time of the Messiah’s coming is fulfilled, he
will return in glory. 2 Then all who have fallen asleep in hope of him
will rise. At that time the storehouses will be opened in which the
number of the souls of the righteous is kept, and they will come out,
and a crowd of souls will be seen together in one gathering, of one
mind. The first will be glad and the last will not be sad. 3 For they
know that the time has come of which it is said that it is the end of
the times. 4 But the souls of the wicked, when they see all this, will
waste away all the more. 5 For they will know that their torment has
come and their ruin has arrived.”

Chapter 31

Baruch urges the people to prepare

1 After this I went to the people and said to them, “Gather all your
elders to me, and I will speak words to them.” 2 They all gathered in the
Kidron valley. 3 I answered and said to them, “Hear, Israel, and I will
speak to you; listen, seed of Jacob, and I will teach you. 4 Do not forget
Zion, but keep the anguish of Jerusalem in mind. 5 For the days are
coming when everything that exists will become prey to corruption,
and will be as though it had never been.”

Chapter 32

1 “But if you prepare your hearts, so that you sow the fruits of the
law in them, it will protect you in that time when the Mighty One is
going to shake the whole creation. 2 After a little while the building
of Zion will be shaken so that it can be built again. 3 But that building
will not last. After a time it will be uprooted again and stay desolate
until the appointed time. 4 Afterward it must be renewed in glory and
made perfect forever. 5 So we should not grieve as much over the evil
that has come now as over the one that is still to come. 6 For there will
be a greater trial than these two tribulations, when the Mighty One
renews His creation. 7 Now do not come near me for a few days, and
do not look for me until I come to you.” 8 When I had said all this to
them, I, Baruch, went my way. When the people saw me leaving, they
raised their voices, wept, and said, 9 “Where are you going, Baruch?

Are you abandoning us like a father who abandons his orphaned children and leaves them?"

Chapter 33

1 "Are these the orders your companion Jeremiah the prophet gave you when he said to you, 2 'Look after these people until I go and prepare the rest of the brothers in Babylon, who have been sentenced to be taken into captivity'? 3 Now if you also leave us, it would be better for us all to die before you, and then for you to leave us."

Chapter 34

Baruch's lament

1 I answered the people, "Far be it from me to leave you or withdraw from you. I will only go to the Holy of Holies to ask the Mighty One about you and about Zion, in case I may receive more light. After this I will come back to you."

Chapter 35

1 I, Baruch, went to the holy place, sat down on the ruins, wept, and said, 2 "If only my eyes were springs and my eyelids a fountain of tears. 3 How can I lament for Zion? How can I mourn for Jerusalem? 4 In the place where I now lie face down, the high priest once offered holy sacrifices and placed on it incense of fragrant spices. 5 Now our pride has been turned to dust, and the desire of our soul to sand."

Chapter 36

The vision of the forest, the vine, the fountain, and the cedar

1 When I had said this, I fell asleep there, and in the night I saw a vision. 2 There was a forest of trees planted on a plain, and tall, rugged, rocky mountains surrounded it. That forest took up a lot of room. 3 Then, facing it, a vine rose up, and from beneath it a spring flowed out peacefully. 4 The spring came to the forest and rose into great waves. The waves flooded the forest, and suddenly they tore up most of it and knocked down all the mountains around it. 5 The tops of the forest began to be brought low, and the peaks of the mountains were made low, and the spring was so strong that it left nothing of

that great forest except one cedar. [6] When it had thrown that forest down and destroyed and uprooted most of it, so that nothing was left and even its place could not be recognized, the vine came with the spring, in peace and great calm, to a place not far from the cedar. They brought the fallen cedar to the vine. [7] I looked, and the vine opened its mouth and spoke to the cedar. It said, "Are you not the cedar that was left from the forest of wickedness, through whom wickedness lasted and was done all those years, and goodness never? [8] You kept conquering what was not yours, and you never showed compassion to what was yours. You kept stretching your power over those far from you, and you held those who came near you fast in the traps of your wickedness. You always lifted yourself up as if you could never be torn out! [9] But now your time has run out and your hour has come. [10] So you also depart, cedar, after the forest that went before you, and turn to dust with it, and let your ashes be mixed together. [11] Now lie down in anguish and rest in torment until your last time comes, when you will come again and be tormented still more."

Chapter 37

[1] After this I saw that cedar burning and the vine growing, with the plain around it full of flowers that never fade. [2] Then I woke up and got up.

Chapter 38

The vision explained

[1] I prayed and said, "O Lord, my Lord, You always give light to those who are led by understanding. [2] Your law is life, and Your wisdom is the right way. [3] So make known to me the meaning of this vision. [4] You know that my soul has always walked in Your law, and from my earliest days I never left Your wisdom."

Chapter 39

[1] He answered me, "Baruch, this is the meaning of the vision you saw. [2] You saw the great forest surrounded by tall, rugged mountains. This is what it means. [3] See, the days are coming when this kingdom, which once destroyed Zion, will itself be destroyed and made subject to the

one that comes after it. 4 After a time that one too will be destroyed,
and another, a third, will rise, and it will also hold power for its time
and be destroyed. 5 After this a fourth kingdom will rise, whose power
will be harsher and more evil than any before it. It will rule for many
times as long as the forests on the plain, hold on for ages, and lift
itself higher than the cedars of Lebanon[a]. 6 Truth will be hidden by it,
and all who are stained with wrongdoing will flee to it, as wild beasts
flee and creep into a forest. 7 When the time comes near for it to fall,
then the rule of My Messiah will be revealed, which is like the spring
and the vine. When it is revealed, it will tear out the multitude of its
army. 8 As for the tall cedar left over from that forest, and the vine
speaking to it the words you heard, this is what it means."

Notes

- a (39:5) "Lebanon" (Hebrew *Levanon*) means "white," perhaps for its snowy peaks.

Chapter 40

1 "The last ruler of that time will be left alive after the multitude of
his armies has been put to the sword. He will be bound, and they will
take him up to Mount Zion, and My Messiah will convict him of all
his godless deeds. He will gather and set before him all the works of
his armies. 2 Afterward he will put him to death and protect the rest
of My people, who will be found in the place I have chosen. 3 His rule
will stand forever, until the world of corruption comes to an end and
the times I have mentioned are fulfilled. 4 This is your vision, and this
is what it means."

Chapter 41

The apostates and the converts

1 I answered, "For whom, and for how many, will these things be?
Who will be worthy to live at that time? 2 I will say before You every-
thing I am thinking, and I will ask You about what I am pondering. 3
I see many of Your people who have turned from Your covenant and
thrown off the yoke of Your law. 4 But I have seen others who gave
up their emptiness and fled for shelter under Your wings. 5 What will
happen to them? How will the last time receive them? 6 Or perhaps

their time will be weighed, and they will be judged as the balance tips?"

Chapter 42

1 He answered me, "I will show you this too. 2 As for what you said, 'For whom will these things be, and for how many?' To those who have believed, the good that was promised long ago will come, and to those who despise it, the opposite. 3 As for what you said about those who have drawn near and those who have withdrawn, this is the answer. 4 Those who were first subject to Me and afterward turned away and mingled with the seed of mixed peoples: the time of these was the former time, and it was counted as something exalted. 5 And those who did not know before, but afterward came to know life and mingled only with the seed of the people that had set itself apart: the time of these is the latter time, and it is counted as something exalted. 6 Time will follow time and season will follow season. One will receive from another, and then, with the end in view, everything will be compared by the measure of the times and the hours of the seasons. 7 For corruption will take what belongs to it, and life will take what belongs to it. 8 The dust will be called and told, 'Give back what is not yours, and raise up everything you have kept until its time.'"

Chapter 43

Baruch is told of his death

1 "But you, Baruch, turn your heart to what has been said to you, and understand what has been shown to you, for there are many everlasting comforts for you. 2 You will leave this place and pass from the regions you now see. You will forget whatever is corruptible and will no longer remember what happens among mortals. 3 So go and command your people, and come to this place. After that, fast for seven days, and then I will come to you and speak with you."

Chapter 44

Baruch tells the elders of his coming death

1 I, Baruch, went from there and came to my people. I called my firstborn son, and the Gedaliahs, my friends, and seven of the elders

of the people, and I said to them, [2] “See, I am going to my fathers, the way of all the earth. [3] But do not leave the way of the law. Guard the people who remain and warn them, so that they do not turn from the commands of the Mighty One. [4] You see that the One we serve is just, and that our Creator shows no favoritism. [5] See what has happened to Zion, and what has come upon Jerusalem. [6] By this the judgment of the Mighty One will be made known, and His ways, which cannot be traced out yet are right. [7] If you endure and keep on in His fear and do not forget His law, the times will change for the better over you, and you will see the comfort of Zion. [8] For whatever exists now is nothing, but what is to come is very great. [9] Everything corruptible will pass away and everything that dies will go. All the present time will be forgotten, and there will be no memory of the present time, which is stained with evils. [10] For what runs on now runs toward emptiness, and what prospers will quickly fall and be humbled. [11] What is to come will be the object of desire, and we will hope for what comes after. It is a time that does not pass away. [12] The hour comes that lasts forever, and the new world comes, which does not turn to corruption those who go to its blessing, has no mercy on those who go to torment, and does not lead to ruin those who live in it. [13] These are the ones who will inherit the time that has been spoken of, and theirs is the inheritance of the promised time. [14] These are the ones who have gathered for themselves treasures of wisdom, and with them are found stores of understanding. They have not turned away from mercy, and they have kept the truth of the law. [15] To them the world to come will be given, but the dwelling of the rest, who are many, will be in the fire.”

Chapter 45

[1] “So, as far as you can, teach the people, for that work is ours. [2] If you teach them, you will give them life.”

Chapter 46

[1] My son and the elders of the people answered me, “Has the Mighty One humbled us so much as to take you from us so quickly? [2] We will truly be in darkness, with no light for the people who are left. [3] Where

will we look for the law again, and who will tell us the difference between death and life?" [4] I said to them, "I cannot resist the throne of the Mighty One. Even so, Israel will never lack a wise man, nor the family of Jacob a son of the law. [5] Only prepare your hearts to obey the law, and be subject to those who are wise and understanding in fear of Him. Prepare your souls so that you do not leave them. [6] If you do these things, good news will come to you. [7] That is what I told you before, and you will not fall into the torment of which I warned you earlier. [8] But about the word that I was to be taken, I did not tell them or my son.

Chapter 47

[1] When I had gone out and sent them away, I went there and said to them, "See, I am going to Hebron[a], for the Mighty One has sent me there." [2] I came to the place where the word had been spoken to me, sat there, and fasted for seven days.

Notes

- a (47:1) "Hebron" (Hebrew *Chevron*) is related to "association" or "league." It is a city in the hills south of Jerusalem.

Chapter 48

Baruch's prayer and the answer

[1] After the seventh day I prayed before the Mighty One and said, [2] "O my Lord, You call the coming of the times, and they stand before You. You make the power of the ages pass away, and they do not resist You. You set the order of the seasons, and they obey You. [3] You alone know how long the generations last, and You do not reveal Your mysteries to many. [4] You make known how great the fire is, and You weigh how light the wind is. [5] You search out the limits of the heights, and You examine the depths of the darkness. [6] You look after the number of those who pass away, so that they may be kept, and You prepare a home for those who are to come. [7] You remember the beginning that You made, and You do not forget the destruction that is to come. [8] At Your nod, in fear and anger, You command the flames, and they change into spirits. With a word You bring to life what was not, and with mighty power You hold back what has not yet come. [9] You

teach created things to understand You, and You make the heavenly spheres wise so that they serve in their ranks. [10] Countless armies stand before You and quietly serve in their ranks at Your nod. [11] Hear Your servant and listen to my plea. [12] We are born in a short time, and in a short time we return. [13] But with You hours are like an age, and days are like generations. [14] So do not be angry with humanity, for it is nothing, [15] and do not hold our deeds against us. What are we? It is by Your gift that we come into the world, and we do not leave by our own will. [16] We never said to our parents, 'Give birth to us,' and we never sent word to Sheol, saying, 'Take us in.' [17] What is our strength, that we could bear Your wrath? What are we, that we could stand Your judgment? [18] Shelter us in Your compassion, and help us in Your mercy. [19] Look at the little ones who are subject to You, and save everyone who comes near You. Do not destroy our people's hope, and do not cut short the times of our help. [20] This is the nation You chose, and these are the people for whom You find no equal. [21] But now I will speak before You and say what my heart thinks. [22] We trust in You, for Your law is with us, and we know that we will not fall as long as we keep Your statutes. [23] We are blessed forever in this at least, that we have not mingled with the nations. [24] For we are all one famous people who received one law from the One. The law among us will help us, and the surpassing wisdom in us will assist us." [25] When I had prayed and said these things, I was greatly weakened. [26] He answered me, "You have prayed simply, Baruch, and all your words have been heard. [27] But My judgment claims what is its own, and My law claims its rights. [28] I will answer you from your own words, and speak to you from your own prayer. [29] It is like this: one who is corrupted is no more. He has done wrong as far as he was able, and he has not remembered My goodness or accepted My patience. [30] So you will surely be taken up, as I told you before. [31] For a time will rise that brings affliction. It will come and pass by with swift violence, and it will be stormy, coming in the heat of anger. [32] In those days all the inhabitants of the earth will be stirred up against one another, because they do not know that My judgment has come near. [33] Not many wise people will be found in that time, and the intelligent

will be only a few. Even those who know will mostly stay silent. [34] There will be many rumors and plenty of news. Illusions will be seen at work, and many promises will be told. Some will turn out empty, and some will be confirmed. [35] Honor will turn into shame, strength will be crushed into contempt, integrity will be destroyed, and beauty will become ugliness. [36] In that time many will say to many, 'Where has the multitude of understanding hidden itself, and where has the multitude of wisdom gone?' [37] While they are thinking this over, envy will rise in those who thought nothing of themselves, and passion will seize the peaceful. Many will be stirred up in anger to hurt many, and they will raise armies to shed blood, and in the end they will perish along with them. [38] At that same time a change of the times will be plain to everyone, because throughout those times they made themselves unclean, practiced oppression, each walked in his own works, and did not remember the law of the Mighty One. [39] So a fire will consume their thoughts, and in flames the plans of their inmost being will be tested. For the Judge will come and will not delay. [40] Each of the inhabitants of the earth knew when he was breaking the law, but in their pride they did not know My Law. [41] Then many will certainly weep, more over the living than over the dead." [42] I answered, "O Adam, what have you done to all those born from you? And what will be said to the first Eve[a], who listened to the serpent? [43] This whole multitude is heading toward corruption, and there is no counting those the fire devours. [44] But I will speak again in Your presence. [45] You, O Lord, my Lord, know what is in Your creature. [46] Long ago You commanded the dust to bring forth Adam, and You know the number of those born from him, and how far they have sinned before You, who lived and did not confess You as their Creator. [47] As for all of these, their end will convict them, and Your law, which they broke, will repay them on Your day." [48] "But now let us set the wicked aside and ask about the righteous. [49] I will describe their blessedness and will not be silent in celebrating their glory, which is kept for them. [50] For just as you have endured much labor for a little time in this passing world where you live, so in that world that has no end you will receive great light."

Notes

- a (48:42) "Eve" (Hebrew *Chavvah*) is traditionally linked to "life" or "living."

Chapter 49

The nature of the resurrection body

1 "Even so, I will ask You again, Mighty One, and I will ask You, who made all things. 2 In what form will those live who live in Your day? How will the splendor of those who come after that time continue? 3 Will they take on this present form again and put on these tangled limbs, which are now caught up in evils and in which evils reach their peak? Or will You perhaps change these things that have been in the world, just as You change the world?"

Chapter 50

1 He answered me, "Listen to this word, Baruch, and write in the memory of your heart everything you will learn. 2 The earth will then surely give back the dead, which it now receives to keep. It will make no change in their form, but as it received them, so it will return them. As I handed them over to it, so it will raise them. 3 For then it will be necessary to show the living that the dead have come back to life and that those who had departed have returned. 4 When they have each recognized those they know now, then the judgment will grow strong, and the things that were spoken of before will come."

Chapter 51

1 "When that appointed day has passed, the appearance of those who are condemned will be changed, and so will the glory of those who are declared righteous. 2 The appearance of those who now do evil will become worse than it is, since they will suffer torment. 3 As for the glory of those who have now been made righteous in My law, who have had understanding in their lives and have planted the root of wisdom in their hearts, their splendor will be glorified in changes, and the form of their faces will be turned into the light of their beauty, so that they may gain and receive the world that does not die, which is then promised to them. 4 Above all, those who come then will grieve over this: that they rejected My law and stopped their ears so as not to

hear wisdom or receive understanding. [5] When they see those whom they now look down on, who will then be lifted up and glorified more than they are, the righteous will be transformed into the splendor of angels, and the wicked will waste away still more in wonder at the sights and the forms they behold. [6] For they will see first, and afterward go away to be tormented. [7] But those who were saved by their works, for whom the law has been a hope, understanding an expectation, and wisdom a confidence, will see wonders appear in their time. [8] They will see the world that is now invisible to them, and they will see the time that is now hidden from them. [9] Time will no longer age them. [10] They will live in the heights of that world, and they will be made like the angels and equal to the stars. They will be changed into any form they wish, from beauty into loveliness, and from light into the splendor of glory. [11] The wide spaces of Paradise will be spread out before them, and the beauty of the majesty of the living creatures beneath the throne will be shown to them, along with all the armies of angels, who are now held back by My word so that they do not appear, and are held by a command to stand in their places until their coming arrives. [12] Moreover, there will then be an excellence in the righteous that surpasses that of the angels. [13] For the first will receive the last, whom they were expecting, and the last will receive those of whom they used to hear that they had passed away. [14] For they have been rescued from this world of tribulation and have laid down the burden of anguish. [15] What have people lost their lives for, and what have those on the earth traded their souls for? [16] They did not choose for themselves that time which, beyond the reach of anguish, could never pass away. They chose for themselves the time whose outcomes are full of lamentation and evil. They denied the world that does not age those who come to it, and they rejected the time of glory, so that they will not come to the honor of which I told you before."

Chapter 52

[1] I answered, "How could we forget those for whom woe is then kept in store? [2] Why, then, do we mourn again for those who die? Why do

we weep for those who go down to Sheol? [3] Let the lamentations be kept for the start of that coming torment, and let the tears be stored up for the arrival of the destruction of that time. [4] But even in the face of these things I will speak. [5] And as for the righteous, what will they do now? [6] Rejoice in the suffering you now endure. Why do you look for the decline of your enemies? [7] Make your souls ready for what is kept for you, and prepare them for the reward laid up for you."

Chapter 53

The vision of the cloud with dark and bright waters

[1] After I had said these things, I fell asleep there, and I saw a vision. A cloud was rising from a very great sea. I kept looking at it, and it was full of white and black waters, with many colors in those same waters, and at its top there was what looked like great lightning. [2] I saw the cloud moving swiftly in quick courses, and it covered all the earth. [3] After this the cloud began to pour out on the earth the waters it held. [4] I saw that the waters coming down from it were not all alike. [5] At the first they were black and many. Then I saw the waters become bright, but they were not many. After this I saw black waters again, then bright, then black again, and bright again. [6] This happened twelve times, but the black were always more numerous than the bright. [7] At the end of the cloud it rained black waters, darker than all the earlier waters, and fire was mixed with them. Where those waters came down, they brought devastation and destruction. [8] After this I saw the lightning I had seen at the top of the cloud seize the cloud and hurl it to the earth. [9] That lightning shone so brightly that it lit up the whole earth, and it healed the regions where the last waters had come down and brought devastation. [10] It took hold of the whole earth and ruled over it. [11] After this I saw twelve rivers rising from the sea, and they began to surround the lightning and become subject to it. [12] In my fear I woke up.

Chapter 54

Baruch asks for the meaning of the vision

1 I pleaded with the Mighty One and said, “You alone, Lord, know the
deep things of the world from ages past. You bring about by Your
word what happens in its times. In response to the works of the
inhabitants of the earth You hurry the beginnings of the times, and
You alone know the end of the seasons. 2 Nothing is too hard for You,
and You do everything easily with a nod. 3 To You the depths are like
the heights, and the beginnings of the ages serve Your word. 4 You
reveal to those who fear You what is prepared for them, so that from
then on they may be comforted. 5 You show great deeds to those who
do not know. You break open the walls around the ignorant. You light
up what is dark and reveal what is hidden to the pure, who in faith
have submitted to You and Your law. 6 You have shown this vision
to Your servant. Show me its meaning as well. 7 I know that I have
received an answer about the things I asked, and in answer to my
request You showed me with what voice to praise You and with what
limbs to send up praises and hallelujahs to You. 8 Even if my limbs
were mouths and the hairs of my head were voices, I still could not
give You the praise You deserve, nor honor You as is fitting. I could
not recount Your praise or tell the glory of Your beauty. 9 What am I
among people, or why am I counted among those better than I am,
that I have heard all these marvelous things from the Most High and
countless promises from the One who made me? 10 Blessed be my
mother among those who bear children, and praised among women
be she who gave birth to me. 11 I will not be silent in praising the
Mighty One, and with the voice of praise I will tell of His marvelous
deeds. 12 Who does anything like Your marvelous deeds, O God? Who
can grasp Your deep thought about life? 13 By Your counsel You govern
all the creatures that Your right hand made. You set every fountain of
light beside You, and You prepared the treasures of wisdom beneath
Your throne. 14 Those who have not loved Your law rightly perish,
and the torment of judgment awaits those who have not submitted to
Your power. 15 Adam sinned first and brought early death on everyone,
but of those born from him, each one has prepared torment to come
for his own soul, and each has also chosen glories to come for himself.
16 Whoever believes will certainly receive a reward. 17 But as for you

wicked ones who live now, go and turn toward destruction, because you will soon be visited, since you rejected the understanding of the Most High. 18 His works have not taught you, and the skill of His creation, always before you, has not persuaded you. 19 So Adam is not the cause except of his own soul, but each of us has become the Adam of his own soul. 20 But You, Lord, explain to me the things You have revealed to me, and tell me about what I asked You. 21 At the completion of the world, vengeance will be taken on those who have done wickedness, according to their wickedness, and You will glorify the faithful according to their faithfulness. 22 You rule over those who belong to You, and You blot out from among Your own those who sin."

Chapter 55

1 When I had finished speaking the words of this prayer, I sat down there under a tree to rest in the shade of its branches. 2 I wondered and was amazed, and I thought about the abundance of goodness that sinners on the earth have rejected, and about the great torment they have despised, although they knew they would be tormented because of the sin they had committed. 3 While I was thinking about these and similar things, the angel Ramiel[a], who is in charge of true visions, was sent to me, and he said to me, 4 "Baruch, why does your heart trouble you, and why does your thought disturb you? 5 If you are so moved by a mere report of the judgment, what will you do when you see it clearly with your own eyes? 6 If you are so overcome by waiting for the day of the Mighty One, what will you do when you come to its arrival? 7 If you are so completely distraught at the word announcing the torment of those who have acted foolishly, how much more when the event itself shows its marvels? 8 If you have heard news of the good and evil things that are then coming and are grieved, what will you do when you see what the Majesty will reveal, which will convict some and make others rejoice?"

Notes

- a (55:3) "Ramiel" (Hebrew *Remiel*) is thought to mean "thunder of God" or "God has raised up."

Chapter 56

Interpretation: the dark and bright waters

1 "Since you asked the Most High to explain the vision you saw, I
have been sent to tell you. 2 The Mighty One has truly made known
to you the course of the times that have passed and those that are
meant to pass in His world, from the beginning of its creation to its
completion, both what is deceit and what is truth. 3 The great cloud
you saw rising from the sea and going on to cover the earth is the
duration of the world, which the Mighty One made when He decided
to make the world. 4 When the word went out from His presence,
the duration of the world came into being in a small way, and it was
established according to the fullness of the understanding of the One
who sent it. 5 The black waters you saw first at the top of the cloud,
which came down on the earth first, are the transgression that Adam,
the first man, committed. 6 For from the time he transgressed, early
death came into being, grief was given a name, anguish was prepared,
pain was created, trouble was brought to its height, and disease began
to take hold. Sheol kept demanding to be renewed with blood. The
bearing of children came about, the passion of parents arose, human
greatness was brought low, and goodness withered. 7 What could be
blacker or darker than these things? 8 This is the beginning of the
black waters you saw. 9 From these black waters, black waters came
again, and the darkness of darkness was produced. 10 He became a
danger to his own soul, and even to the angels. 11 At that time, when he
was created, they had enjoyed freedom. 12 Because he became a danger
to them, some of them came down and mingled with the women.
13 Then those who did this were tormented in chains. 14 But the rest
of the multitude of angels, who cannot be counted, held themselves
back. 15 Those who lived on the earth perished together with them in
the waters of the flood. 16 These are the first black waters."

Chapter 57

1 "After these waters you saw bright waters. This is the fountain of
Abraham, together with his generations and the coming of his son
and his son's son, and of those like them. 2 At that time the unwritten

law was known among them, the works of the commandments were fulfilled, belief in the coming judgment arose, hope in the world that was to be renewed was built up, and the promise of the life to come was planted. 3 These are the bright waters you saw."

Chapter 58

1 "The black third waters you saw are the mixing together of all sins that the nations committed after the death of those righteous men, and the wickedness of the land of Egypt[a], where they acted wickedly in the service by which they made their sons serve. 2 Yet even these perished in the end."

Notes

- a (58:1) "Egypt" translates the Hebrew *Mitsrayim*, of uncertain meaning.

Chapter 59

1 "The bright fourth waters you saw are the coming of Moses, Aaron[a], Miriam[b], Joshua[c] son of Nun, Caleb[d], and all those like them. 2 At that time the lamp of the eternal law shone on all who sat in darkness. It announced the promised reward to those who believe, and the torment of fire kept for them to those who deny. 3 At that time even the heavens were shaken from their place, and those under the throne of the Mighty One were disturbed when He took Moses to Himself. 4 He showed him many warnings, together with the principles of the law and the end of the times, as He has to you also, and likewise the pattern of Zion and its measurements, on the pattern of which the sanctuary of the present time was to be made. 5 He also showed him the extent of the fire, the depths of the abyss, the weight of the winds, and the number of the drops of rain, 6 the restraint of anger, the abundance of patience, and the truth of judgment, 7 the root of wisdom, the riches of understanding, and the spring of knowledge, 8 the height of the air, the greatness of Paradise, the end of the ages, and the start of the day of judgment, 9 the number of the offerings, and the worlds that have not yet come, 10 the mouth of Gehenna, the place where vengeance stands, the place of faith, and the region of hope, 11 the likeness of future torment, the multitude of countless

angels, the flaming hosts, the splendor of the lightnings, the voice of the thunders, the ranks of the chief angels, the treasuries of light, the changes of the times, and the study of the law. [12] These are the bright fourth waters you saw."

Notes

- a (59:1) "Aaron" (Hebrew *Aharon*) is of uncertain meaning.
- b (59:1) "Miriam" (Hebrew *Miryam*) is of uncertain meaning; it may be related to "bitter" or "beloved."
- c (59:1) "Joshua" (Hebrew *Yehoshua*) means "Yahweh saves."
- d (59:1) "Caleb" (Hebrew *Kalev*) is often taken to mean "dog" or "wholehearted."

Chapter 60

[1] "The black fifth waters you saw raining are the works the Amorites did, the spells of their incantations, the wickedness of their mysteries, and the mixing of their pollution. [2] Even Israel was defiled by sins in the days of the judges, although they saw many signs from the One who made them."

Chapter 61

[1] "The bright sixth waters you saw are the time when David[a] and Solomon[b] were born. [2] At that time Zion was built, the sanctuary was dedicated, much blood of the nations that sinned then was shed, and many offerings were made at the dedication of the sanctuary. [3] There was peace and calm at that time. [4] Wisdom was heard in the assembly, and the riches of understanding were honored in the congregations. [5] The holy festivals were kept in blessing and great joy. [6] The judgment of the rulers was seen to be without deceit, and the righteousness of the Mighty One's precepts was carried out in truth. [7] The land was loved by the Lord at that time, and because its inhabitants did not sin, it was glorified above all lands, and the city of Zion ruled over all lands and regions. [8] These are the bright waters you saw."

Notes

- a (61:1) "David" (Hebrew *David*) probably means "beloved."
- b (61:1) "Solomon" (Hebrew *Shelomoh*) is related to *shalom*, "peace."

Chapter 62

1 "The black seventh waters you saw are the perversion that came
from the plan of Jeroboam[a], who planned to make two golden calves,
2 and all the wrongdoing that the kings after him did wickedly. 3
They are the curse of Jezebel[b] and the worship of idols that Israel
practiced at that time, 4 the withholding of rain, and the famines that
happened until women ate the fruit of their own wombs, 5 and the
time of captivity that came on the nine and a half tribes, because they
were in many sins. 6 Shalmaneser[c], king of Assyria[d], came and led
them away captive. 7 As for the nations, it would be tiresome to tell
how they always practiced ungodliness and wickedness and never
did righteousness. 8 These are the black seventh waters you saw."

Notes

- a (62:1) "Jeroboam" (Hebrew *Yarovam*) is usually explained as "the people contend" or "may the kinsman increase."
- b (62:3) "Jezebel" (Hebrew *Izevel*) is a Phoenician name, perhaps meaning "where is the prince?"
- c (62:6) "Shalmaneser" (Assyrian *Shulmanu-asharedu*) means "Shulmanu is foremost."
- d (62:6) "Assyria" (Hebrew *Ashshur*) is named for its chief city and god, Ashur.

Chapter 63

1 "The bright eighth waters you saw are the uprightness and honesty
of Hezekiah[a], king of Judah, and the grace that came upon him. 2
For Sennacherib[b] was stirred up, so that he would perish, and his
rage troubled him, so that he would perish by it, together with the
multitude of the nations that were with him. 3 When King Hezekiah
heard what the king of Assyria was planning, which was to come
and seize him and destroy his people, the two and a half tribes that
remained, and even to overthrow Zion also, Hezekiah trusted in his
works and hoped in his righteousness, and he spoke with the Mighty
One and said, 4 'See, Sennacherib is ready to destroy us, and he will
be boastful and proud when he has destroyed Zion.' 5 The Mighty
One heard him, for Hezekiah was wise, and He paid attention to his
prayer because he was righteous. 6 Then the Mighty One gave orders
to Ramiel, His angel who speaks with you. 7 And I went out and

destroyed their multitude, the number of whose commanders alone was one hundred eighty-five thousand, and each of them had an equal number under him. [8] At that time I burned their bodies inside, but I kept their clothes and weapons untouched on the outside, so that the still more wonderful deeds of the Mighty One would appear, and so that His name would be spoken of in all the earth. [9] So Zion was saved and Jerusalem delivered, and Israel was freed from tribulation. [10] All who were in the holy land rejoiced, and the name of the Mighty One was glorified, so that it was spoken of everywhere. [11] These are the bright waters you saw."

Notes

- a (63:1) "Hezekiah" (Hebrew *Chizqiyyahu*) means "Yahweh strengthens."
- b (63:2) "Sennacherib" (Assyrian *Sin-ahhe-eriba*) means "Sin (the moon god) has replaced the brothers."

Chapter 64

[1] "The black ninth waters you saw are all the wickedness in the days of Manasseh[a], son of Hezekiah. [2] He did much that was ungodly. He killed the righteous, twisted judgment, shed the blood of the innocent, and violently defiled married women. He overturned the altars, destroyed their offerings, and drove out their priests so that they could not serve in the sanctuary. [3] He made an image with five faces. Four of them looked toward the four winds, and the fifth, on top of the image, stood as an opponent of the zeal of the Mighty One. [4] Then wrath went out from the presence of the Mighty One so that Zion would be uprooted, as also happened in your days. [5] A decree also went out against the two and a half tribes, that they too would be led away captive, as you have now seen. [6] Manasseh's ungodliness grew so great that it removed the praise of the Most High from the sanctuary. [7] For this reason Manasseh was called 'the ungodly' at that time, and in the end his dwelling was in the fire. [8] Though his prayer was heard by the Most High, in the end, when he was thrown into the bronze horse and the bronze horse melted, it served as a sign to him for the hour. [9] He had not lived perfectly, for he was not worthy.

But from then on he would know by whom he would finally be tormented. [10] For the One who is able to help is also able to torment."

Notes

- a (64:1) "Manasseh" (Hebrew *Menashsheh*) means "he who makes forget."

Chapter 65

[1] "So Manasseh acted ungodly and thought that in his time the Mighty One would not look into these things. [2] These are the black ninth waters you saw."

Chapter 66

[1] "The bright tenth waters you saw are the pure generations of Josiah[a], king of Judah, who was the only one at that time who submitted to the Mighty One with all his heart and all his soul. [2] He cleansed the land of idols and made holy all the vessels that had been defiled. He restored the offerings to the altar and raised the horn of the holy ones. He lifted up the righteous and honored everyone wise in understanding. He brought the priests back to their service and destroyed and removed the magicians, enchanters, and necromancers from the land. [3] Not only did he put to death the ungodly who were alive, but they also took the bones of the dead out of the tombs and burned them with fire. [4] He set up the festivals and the Sabbaths in their holiness, and he burned their defiled ones in the fire. The lying prophets who deceived the people he also burned in the fire, and the people who had listened to them while they lived, he threw into the Kidron brook and heaped stones on them. [5] He was zealous with zeal for the Mighty One with all his soul, and he alone was firm in the law at that time, so that all the days of his life he left no uncircumcised person or anyone who practiced ungodliness in all the land. [6] So he will receive an eternal reward, and he will be glorified with the Mighty One above many at a later time. [7] For his sake and for the sake of those like him, the honorable glories of which you were told before were created and prepared. These are the bright waters you saw."

Notes

- a (66:1) "Josiah" (Hebrew *Yoshiyyahu*) probably means "Yahweh supports."

Chapter 67

1 “The black eleventh waters you saw are the calamity that is now
falling on Zion. 2 Do you think there is no anguish among the angels
in the presence of the Mighty One, that Zion was handed over like
this, and that the nations boast in their hearts, gather before their
idols, and say, ‘She who so often trampled others is trampled down,
and she who enslaved others has been enslaved’? 3 Do you think the
Most High rejoices in these things, or that His name is glorified? 4 But
how will it serve His righteous judgment? 5 After these things, those
scattered among the nations will be seized by tribulation, and they
will live in shame in every place. 6 For as long as Zion is handed over
and Jerusalem laid waste, idols will prosper in the cities of the nations.
The fragrant smoke of the incense of righteousness that comes by the
law will be put out in Zion, and in every place in the region of Zion
there will be the smoke of ungodliness. 7 But the king of Babylon,
who has now destroyed Zion, will rise up and boast over the people,
and he will say great things in his heart before the Most High. 8 But
he too will fall in the end. These are the black waters.”

Chapter 68

1 “The bright twelfth waters you saw are this word. 2 After these things
a time will come when your people fall into distress, so that they all
run the risk of perishing together. 3 Even so, they will be saved, and
their enemies will fall before them. 4 In due time they will have great
joy. 5 At that time, after a short interval, Zion will be rebuilt again, its
offerings will be restored, the priests will return to their service, and
the nations will come to honor it. 6 Even so, it will not be fully as it
was in the beginning. 7 But after these things there will be the fall of
many nations. 8 These are the bright waters you saw.”

Chapter 69

1 “The last waters you saw, which were darker than all those before
them, those that came after the twelfth and were gathered together,
belong to the whole world. 2 The Most High made a division from the
beginning, because He alone knows what will happen. 3 He foresaw

six kinds of the outrages and ungodliness that would be done before Him. [4] And He foresaw six kinds of the good works of the righteous that would be done before Him, besides those that He Himself will do at the completion of the age. [5] For this reason there were no black waters mixed with black, and no bright with bright, for it is the end."

Chapter 70

[1] "Now hear the meaning of the last black waters that are to come after the black ones. This is the word. [2] See, the days are coming. When the time of the age has ripened and the harvest of its evil and good seeds has come, the Mighty One will bring on the earth, its inhabitants, and its rulers a disturbance of spirit and a stupor of heart. [3] They will hate one another and stir one another up to fight. The lowly will rule over the honored, and those of low rank will be lifted above the famous. [4] The many will be handed over to the few, those who were nothing will rule over the strong, the poor will have more than the rich, and the ungodly will exalt themselves above the heroic. [5] The wise will be silent and the foolish will speak. Neither the thinking of people nor the counsel of the mighty will be confirmed then, and the hope of those who hope will not be confirmed. [6] When what was foretold has come to pass, confusion will fall on everyone. Some will fall in battle and some will perish in anguish, [7] and some will be destroyed by their own. Then the Most High will call up the nations He prepared beforehand, and they will come and make war on the leaders who are left at that time. [8] Whoever escapes the war will die in the earthquake, whoever escapes the earthquake will be burned by the fire, and whoever escapes the fire will be destroyed by famine. [9] Whoever, among the victors and the defeated, escapes all these things I have mentioned will be handed over to My servant, the Messiah. [10] For all the earth will devour its inhabitants."

Chapter 71

[1] "The holy land will have mercy on its own and protect its inhabitants at that time. [2] This is the vision you saw, and this is its meaning. [3]

I have come to tell you these things because your prayer has been heard by the Most High."

Chapter 72

1 "Now hear also about the bright lightning that is to come at the end, after these black waters. This is the word. 2 After the signs I told you of before have come, when the nations are in turmoil and the time of My Messiah has come, he will summon all the nations. Some of them he will spare, and some he will put to death. 3 These things will come on the nations that he spares. 4 Every nation that has not known Israel and has not trampled the seed of Jacob will indeed be spared. 5 This is because some from every nation will be made subject to your people. 6 But all who have ruled over you, or have known you, will be given up to the sword."

Chapter 73

1 "When he has brought low everything in the world and has sat down in peace for the age on the throne of his kingdom, then joy will be revealed and rest will appear. 2 Then healing will come down like dew, and disease will withdraw. Worry, anguish, and lamentation will pass from among people, and gladness will spread through the whole earth. 3 No one will die before his time again, and no misfortune will strike suddenly. 4 Judgments, abusive talk, quarrels, revenge, bloodshed, passions, envy, hatred, and everything like these will go into condemnation when they are removed. 5 These are the very things that have filled this world with evils, and because of them human life has been greatly troubled. 6 Wild beasts will come out of the forest and serve people, and asps and dragons will come out of their holes to submit to a little child. 7 Women will no longer have pain when they give birth, and they will not suffer torment when they bring forth the fruit of the womb."

Chapter 74

1 "In those days the reapers will not grow tired and the builders will not be worn out, for the work will move ahead quickly by itself, together with those who do it, in great peace. 2 For that time is the end

of what is corruptible and the beginning of what is not corruptible. [3] So the things that were foretold will belong to it. It is far from evils and near to things that do not die. [4] This is the bright lightning that came after the last dark waters."

Chapter 75

Baruch's hymn

[1] I answered, "Who can understand Your goodness, Lord? It cannot be grasped. [2] Who can search out Your compassion, which has no end? [3] Who can comprehend Your intelligence? [4] Who can recount the thoughts of Your mind? [5] Who among those who are born can hope to reach those things, unless it is someone to whom You are merciful and gracious? [6] If You did not have compassion on humanity, those under Your right hand could not reach those things, but only those counted by name can be called. [7] But if we who exist know why we have come, and submit to the One who brought us out of Egypt, we will come again and remember the things that have passed, and we will rejoice over what has been. [8] But if we do not know why we have come, and do not acknowledge the rule of the One who brought us up out of Egypt, we will come again and look for the things of the present, and be grieved with pain over what has happened."

Chapter 76

Baruch is told to teach the people for forty days

[1] He answered me, "Since the meaning of this vision has been explained to you as you asked, hear the word of the Most High, so that you may know what will happen to you after these things. [2] You will surely depart from this earth, but not to death. You will be kept until the end of the times. [3] So go up to the top of that mountain, and all the regions of that land will pass before you, together with the shape of the inhabited world, the tops of the mountains, the depths of the valleys, the depths of the seas, and the number of the rivers, so that you may see what you are leaving and where you are going. [4] This will happen after forty days. So go now, and during these days

teach the people as far as you can, so that they may learn and not die at the last time, but may learn so that they live in the last times."

Chapter 77

Baruch's address, and his two letters

1 I, Baruch, went there and came to the people. I gathered them
together, from the greatest to the least, and said to them, 2 "Listen,
children of Israel. See how many of you remain from the twelve
tribes of Israel. 3 To you and to your fathers the Lord gave a law more
excellent than any given to all other peoples. 4 Because your brothers
broke the commands of the Most High, He did not spare the earlier
ones, and He gave the later ones also into captivity. He did not leave
a remnant of them, 5 but see, you are here with me. 6 If you direct
your ways rightly, you also will not depart as your brothers departed,
but they will come to you. 7 The One you worship is merciful, the
One in whom you hope is gracious, and He is true, so that He will
do good and not evil. 8 Have you not seen here what has happened
to Zion? 9 Or do you perhaps think the place had sinned and was
overthrown for that reason? Or that the land had acted foolishly
and so was handed over? 10 Do you not know that because of you
who sinned, what did not sin was overthrown, and because of those
who did wickedly, what did not act foolishly was handed over to its
enemies?" 11 The whole people answered me, "As far as we can recall
the good things the Mighty One has done for us, we recall them, and
the things we do not remember He knows in His mercy. 12 Even so,
do this for us, your people: write also to our brothers in Babylon a
letter of teaching and a scroll of hope, so that you may strengthen
them too before you leave us. 13 The shepherds of Israel have perished,
the lamps that gave light have gone out, and the fountains have held
back the streams we used to drink from. 14 We are left in the darkness,
among the trees of the forest, and in the thirst of the wilderness." 15 I
answered them, "Shepherds, lamps, and fountains come from the law.
Though we depart, the law remains. 16 If you therefore respect the law
and give yourselves to wisdom, a lamp will not be missing, a shepherd
will not fail, and a fountain will not dry up. 17 Even so, as you have

asked me, I will write to your brothers in Babylon and send it by men. In the same way I will write to the nine and a half tribes and send it by a bird." 18 On the twenty-first day of the eighth month ([a]October–November), I, Baruch, came and sat down under the oak, in the shade of its branches. No one was with me, and I was alone. 19 I wrote these two letters. One I sent by an eagle to the nine and a half tribes, and the other I sent to those in Babylon by three men. 20 I called the eagle and said these words to it: 21 "The Most High made you higher than all birds. 22 Now go, and do not linger anywhere, do not enter a nest, and do not settle on any tree until you have crossed the breadth of the many waters of the river Euphrates[b] and have gone to the people who live there, and drop this letter to them. 23 Remember that at the time of the flood Noah[c] received an olive branch from a dove when he sent it out from the ark. 24 The ravens also served Elijah[d], bringing him food, as they had been commanded. 25 Solomon, too, in the time of his kingdom, whenever he wished to send or look for anything, commanded a bird to go, and it obeyed him as he commanded. 26 Now do not let this tire you. Turn neither right nor left, but fly straight, so that you keep the command of the Mighty One, as I have told you."

Notes

- a (77:18) October–November: The text says the "eighth month" of the Hebrew calendar, which is Marcheshvan.
- b (77:22) "Euphrates" (Hebrew *Perat*) is the great river of Mesopotamia, whose name means "fruitful."
- c (77:23) "Noah" (Hebrew *Noach*) is linked in Genesis 5 with "rest" or "comfort."
- d (77:24) "Elijah" (Hebrew *Eliyyahu*) means "my God is Yahweh."

Chapter 78

The letter to the nine and a half tribes

1 These are the words of the letter that Baruch, son of Neriah, sent to the nine and a half tribes across the river Euphrates, in which these things were written. 2 Baruch, son of Neriah, says this to the brothers carried into captivity: "Mercy and peace." My brothers, I keep in mind the love of the One who created us. He loved us from of old and never hated us, but above all He trained us. 3 I know that all of us, the twelve tribes, are bound by one bond, since we were born from one father.

4 So I have been all the more careful to leave you the words of this letter before I die, so that you may be comforted about the evils that have come on you, and may also grieve over the evil that has come on your brothers. I also want you to justify His judgment, 5 which He decreed against you, that you be carried away captive, since what you have suffered is out of proportion to what you have done, so that in the last times you may be found worthy of your fathers. 6 So if you consider that you have suffered these things for your good, so that in the end you will not be condemned and tormented, then you will receive eternal hope. Above all, you must destroy from your heart the empty error that caused you to leave this place. 7 If you do this, He will always remember you, He who always promised on our behalf to those more excellent than we are that He will never forget or abandon us, but will gather again, with great mercy, those who were scattered.

Chapter 79

1 Now, my brothers, first learn what happened to Zion: how Nebuchadnezzar[a], king of Babylon, came up against us. 2 We sinned against the One who made us and did not keep the commandments He gave us, yet He has not punished us as we deserved. 3 What happened to you we also suffer in a still greater degree, for it happened to us as well.

Notes

- a (79:1) "Nebuchadnezzar" (Babylonian *Nabu-kudurri-usur*) means "Nabu, protect my heir."

Chapter 80

1 Now, my brothers, I tell you that when the enemy had surrounded the city, the angels of the Most High were sent, and they overthrew the fortifications of the strong wall and destroyed the firm iron corners, which could not be uprooted. 2 Even so, they hid all the vessels of the sanctuary, so that the enemy could not take possession of them. 3 When they had done this, they handed over to the enemy the overthrown wall, the plundered house, the burned temple, and the people, who were overcome because they had been given up, so that the enemy could not boast and say, "By force we have been

able to lay waste even the house of the Most High in war." [4] They have also bound your brothers and led them away to Babylon, and made them live there. [5] But we have been left here, very few. [6] This is the tribulation I wrote to you about. [7] I know that the comfort of the inhabitants of Zion consoles you, since, as long as you knew it was prospering, your comfort was greater than the tribulation you endured in having to leave it.

Chapter 81

[1] Now hear the word about comfort. [2] I was mourning over Zion, and I asked the Most High for mercy, and I said, [3] "How long will these things last for us? Will these evils come on us always?" [4] The Mighty One acted according to the abundance of His mercies, and the Most High according to the greatness of His compassion. He revealed the word to me so that I would receive comfort. He showed me visions so that I would not endure anguish again, and He made known to me the mystery of the times and showed me the coming of the hours.

Chapter 82

[1] So, my brothers, I have written to you so that you may comfort yourselves in the abundance of your tribulations. [2] Know that our Maker will surely avenge us on all our enemies for everything they have done to us. The end that the Most High will bring is very near, and His mercy that is coming and the end of His judgment are not far off at all. [3] We now see the abundance of the nations' prosperity, though they act ungodly, but they will be like a vapor. [4] We see the greatness of their power, though they do wickedly, but they will be made like a drop of water. [5] We see the firmness of their strength, though they resist the Mighty One every hour, but they will be counted as spit. [6] We consider the glory of their greatness, though they do not keep the statutes of the Most High, but they will pass away like smoke. [7] We think about the beauty of their grace, though they deal in pollution, but they will fade away like grass that withers. [8] We consider the strength of their cruelty, though they do not remember its end, but they will be broken like a wave that passes. [9] We take note of the

boasting of their might, though they deny the kindness of God who gave it to them, but they will pass away like a passing cloud.

Chapter 83

[1] For the Most High will surely hasten His times, and He will surely bring on His hours. [2] He will surely judge those who are in His world, and He will visit all things in truth through all their hidden works. [3] He will surely examine the secret thoughts and everything stored in the inner rooms of all the members of the human body, and He will make it plain before everyone with rebuke. [4] So let none of these present things rise into your hearts, but above all let us wait expectantly, because what has been promised to us will come. [5] Let us not now look to the pleasures of the nations in the present, but let us remember what has been promised to us in the end. [6] For the ends of the times and seasons, and whatever goes with them, will surely pass by together. [7] The end of the age will then show the great power of its ruler, when all things come to judgment. [8] So prepare your hearts for what you believed before, so that you do not end up in bondage in both worlds, led away captive here and tormented there. [9] For in everything that exists now, or has passed, or is to come, neither is the evil fully evil, nor again the good fully good. [10] All the health of this time is turning into sickness, [11] all the might of this time is turning into weakness, and all the force of this time is turning into helplessness. [12] Every energy of youth is turning into old age and decline, and every graceful beauty of this time is turning faded and hateful. [13] Every proud rule of the present is turning into humiliation and shame, [14] every praise of the glory of this time is turning into the shame of silence, and every empty splendor and insolence of this time is turning into voiceless ruin. [15] Every delight and joy of this time is turning to worms and corruption, [16] every clamor of the pride of this time is turning into dust and stillness. [17] Every possession of riches in this time is being turned into Sheol alone, [18] all the plunder of passion in this time is turning into unwilling death, and every passion of the desires of this time is turning into a judgment of torment. [19] Every scheme and trick of this time is turning into a proof of the truth, [20]

every sweetness of perfumes in this time is turning into judgment and condemnation, [21] and every love of lying is turning into disgrace through the truth. [22] Since all these things are done now, does anyone think they will not be avenged? But the end of all things will come to the truth.

Chapter 84

[1] See, I have made these things known to you while I am alive. I said it so that you would learn what is excellent, for the Mighty One has commanded me to teach you, and I will set before you some of the commands of His judgment before I die. [2] Remember that Moses once called heaven and earth to witness against you and said, "If you break the law you will be scattered, but if you keep it you will be kept." [3] He also told you other things when you, the twelve tribes, were together in the desert. [4] After his death you threw them away from you, and for this reason what had been foretold came on you. [5] Moses told you before these things happened to you, and now they have happened to you, for you abandoned the law. [6] I also say to you, now that you have suffered, that if you obey what has been said to you, you will receive from the Mighty One whatever has been stored up and kept for you. [7] Let this letter be a testimony between me and you, so that you remember the commands of the Mighty One, and so that I also have a defense before the One who sent me. [8] Remember the law and Zion, the holy land and your brothers, and the covenant of your fathers, and do not forget the festivals and the Sabbaths. [9] Hand on this letter and the traditions of the law to your sons after you, as your fathers handed them on to you. [10] At all times ask persistently and pray earnestly with your whole heart that the Mighty One may be reconciled to you, and that He may not count the multitude of your sins but remember the uprightness of your fathers. [11] For if He does not judge us according to the abundance of His mercies, woe to all of us who are born."

Chapter 85

[1] “Know also that in former times, in the generations of old, our fathers had helpers, righteous men and holy prophets. [2] We were in our own land, and they helped us when we sinned. They interceded for us with the One who made us, because they trusted in their works, and the Mighty One heard their prayer and forgave us. [3] But now the righteous have been gathered, the prophets have fallen asleep, and we too have gone out from the land. Zion has been taken from us, and now we have nothing except the Mighty One and His law. [4] So if we direct and set our hearts in order, we will receive everything we lost, and far better things many times over. [5] What we lost was subject to corruption, and what we will receive will not be corruptible. [6] I have also written like this to our brothers in Babylon, so that I may bear witness to them as well about these very things. [7] Let all the things I have mentioned be always before your eyes, because we are still in the spirit and power of our freedom. [8] Again, the Most High is patient with us here. He has shown us what is to come and has not hidden from us what will happen in the end. [9] So before judgment claims what is its own and truth what is due to it, let us prepare our souls so that we possess and are not possessed, so that we hope and are not put to shame, and so that we rest with our fathers and are not tormented with our enemies. [10] For the youth of the world is past, the strength of creation is already spent, and the coming of the times is very near. Indeed, they have gone by. The pitcher is near the cistern, the ship near the port, the course of the journey near the city, and life near its end. [11] Prepare your souls again, so that when you sail and step off the ship, you may have rest [12] and not be condemned when you depart. For when the Most High brings all these things to pass, there will be no more a place for repentance, no limit to the times, no duration for the hours, no change of ways, no place for prayer, no sending of petitions, no receiving of knowledge, no giving of love, no place of repentance for the soul, no pleading for offenses, no intercession of the fathers, no prayer of the prophets, and no help of the righteous. [13] There is the sentence of corruption, the way of fire, and the path that leads to Gehenna. [14] For this reason there is one law through one, one

age, and an end for all who are in it. [15] Then He will keep safe those He can forgive and at the same time destroy those who are stained with sins."

Chapter 86

[1] When you receive this letter of mine, read it carefully in your congregations. [2] Think it over, above all on the days of your fasts. [3] Remember me by means of this letter, as I also remember you in it, always. Farewell.

Chapter 87

[1] When I had finished all the words of this letter and had written it carefully to its close, I folded it, sealed it securely, tied it to the neck of the eagle, and let it go and sent it off.

4 Baruch

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 When the people of Israel were being carried away captive by
the Chaldean king,[a] God spoke to Jeremiah.[b] "Jeremiah, my chosen
servant," he said, "rise up and leave this city, you and Baruch,[c] because
I am about to lay it in ruins; those who live in it have heaped up so
many sins." 2 Your prayers stand in the middle of it like a firm pillar,
and like a wall of unbreakable steel running all around it. 3 So now,
get up and go out before the Chaldean army has the city ringed. 4
Jeremiah answered, "I beg you, Lord,[d] let your servant speak in your
presence." 5 "Speak, Jeremiah, my chosen one," the Lord answered. 6
So Jeremiah said, "Lord Almighty,[e] are you handing your chosen city
over to the Chaldeans, so that the king and all his people may boast
and say, 'I have beaten the holy city of God'? 7 No, my Lord. But if
that is what you want, then destroy it with your own hands." 8 The
Lord said to Jeremiah, "Because you are my chosen one, get up and
leave this city, you and Baruch, because I am going to destroy it for
the great number of sins of those who live in it. 9 The king and his
army cannot get inside unless I myself open its gates for them. 10 So
get up, go to Baruch, and give him these words. 11 At midnight,[f] after
you have gotten up, climb onto the city walls. I will show you that
they cannot enter until I have brought the city down first." 12 When
the Lord had spoken, he went away from Jeremiah.

Notes

- a (1:1) "Chaldeans" is the Greek form of Hebrew Kasdim, the people who ruled Babylon. The book looks back to the Babylonian conquest of Jerusalem in 587/586 BC (compare 2 Kings 25; Jeremiah 39).
- b (1:1) The Hebrew name Yirmeyahu is often explained as "Yahweh lifts up" or "Yahweh throws down"; the meaning is uncertain.
- c (1:1) Baruch (Hebrew Barukh) means "blessed." He is Jeremiah's scribe in Jeremiah 36 and 45.

- d (1:4) The Greek text has *kyrios*, “Lord,” the word the Greek Bible regularly uses for Yahweh. Throughout the book, “the Lord” renders *kyrios*; the Hebrew name Yahweh itself does not occur in this Greek text.
- e (1:6) Greek *pantokratōr*, “ruler of all,” which the Greek Bible uses for the Hebrew title Yahweh Sabaoth (“Yahweh of Armies”).
- f (1:11) Greek “the sixth hour of the night.” Counting the night hours from about 6 p.m., the sixth hour is about midnight.

Chapter 2

1 Jeremiah hurried to tell Baruch everything. The two of them went to
the Temple of God; there Jeremiah ripped his robe, covered his head
with dust, and walked into the sanctuary of God.[a] 2 When Baruch
saw him with his garments torn and dust on his head, he cried out
in a loud voice, “Father Jeremiah, what has happened to you? What
dreadful sin has the people committed?” 3 Each time the people had
sinned, Jeremiah would throw dust over his head and plead for them,
until their sin was forgiven. 4 So Baruch asked him, “Father, why are
you doing this? What is going on?” 5 Jeremiah said to him, “Rather,
let us tear open our hearts, and not fetch water for the troughs. Let
us weep until our tears fill them, because the Lord will show this
people no pity.” 6 Baruch said, “Father Jeremiah, what has happened?”
7 Jeremiah said, “God is handing the city over to the king of the
Chaldeans, to carry the people away captive to Babylon.” 8 When
Baruch heard it, he tore his own robe too. “Father Jeremiah,” he said,
“who told you this?” 9 Jeremiah said to him, “Stay with me a little
while, until midnight, so that you can know that this word is true.”
10 So the two of them remained beside the altar,[b] weeping, with their
clothes torn.

Notes

- a (2:1) The Greek says “the sanctuary (*hagiastērion*) of God,” meaning the Temple.
- b (2:10) The Greek word is *thysiastērion*, “the place of sacrifice, altar.”

Chapter 3

1 When the hour of night came that the Lord had spoken of to Jere-
miah, Jeremiah and Baruch went together up onto the city walls. 2 A
trumpet sounded, and angels came out of heaven carrying torches in

their hands, and they stood on the walls of the city. [3] When Jeremiah and Baruch saw the angels, they wept. "Now we know the word is true," they said. [4] Then Jeremiah pleaded with the angels: "I ask you not to destroy the city yet, until I have spoken to the Lord." [5] The Lord said to the angels, "Do not destroy the city until I have spoken with my chosen servant Jeremiah." [6] Jeremiah said, "I beg you, Lord, allow me to speak in your presence." [7] The Lord said, "Speak, my chosen Jeremiah." [8] Jeremiah said, "Look, Lord, we now know that you are handing the city over to its enemies, and they will carry the people off to Babylon. [9] What would you have me do with the sacred vessels used in the Temple's worship?" [10] The Lord answered, "Take them, give them over to the earth, and say: 'Listen, earth, to the voice of the one who shaped you, who set you down amid the waters,[a] and who sealed you with seven seals through seven seasons. After all this, you will be given back your adornment. [11] Keep safe the sacred vessels of the Temple until the beloved ones are gathered.'" [12] Jeremiah said, "Lord, show me, I pray, what I ought to do for Abimelech the Ethiopian.[b] He has shown great kindness to the people and to your servant Jeremiah. [13] For he is the one who lifted me out of the muddy pit.[c] I do not want him to see the ruin of the city and its desolation; instead, be merciful to him, so that he is not grieved." [14] The Lord said to Jeremiah, "Send him away to the estate of Agrippa[d] by way of the mountain, and I will shelter him until I bring your people back to the city. [15] And you, Jeremiah, go with your people to Babylon, and stay there preaching the good news to them,[e] until I bring them back to the city. [16] Baruch must stay here while I speak with him." [17] When he had said this, the Lord went up from Jeremiah into heaven. [18] Then Jeremiah and Baruch went into the sanctuary and took the holy vessels of the service; they handed them over to the earth, just as the Lord had told them. [19] Right away, the earth swallowed them up. [20] And the two sat down and wept. [21] At daybreak Jeremiah sent Abimelech off, saying, "Take a basket, and go along the mountain road to the estate of Agrippa. Bring back a few figs for the sick among the people, because the Lord's favor rests on you and his glory crowns your head." [22] Abimelech went, as he had been told.

Notes

- a (3:10) Greek "in the abundance (or fullness) of the waters." Ancient writers pictured the earth as a land set in the waters of the sea (compare Psalm 24:2).
- b (3:12) "Ethiopian" translates Greek *Aithiops* (Hebrew Kushi, "Cushite"), a man from the upper Nile region south of Egypt. He is the court official of Jeremiah 38:7–13 and 39:15–18.
- c (3:13) Greek *lakkos tou borborou*, "the pit of mud"; compare the cistern in Jeremiah 38:6, where Jeremiah sank into the mud.
- d (3:14) "Agrippa" is the name the Greek gives to a country property near Jerusalem. It is a Greek or Latin name not otherwise known from Jeremiah's time, which is one sign that the book was composed long after the events it describes.
- e (3:15) The Greek participle *euangelizomenos* means "bringing good news." It is the verb the New Testament uses for preaching the gospel; here it describes Jeremiah's message of comfort and return to the exiles.

Chapter 4

1 When morning came, the army of the Chaldeans appeared and surrounded the city.

2 Then the great angel sounded the trumpet and called out, "Come in, you forces of the Chaldeans, for the gate has been opened to you."

3 "Let the king come in with his multitude, and let him carry all the people away captive."

4 Jeremiah took the Temple keys, went out beyond the city, and hurled them toward the sun,[a] calling out, "Sun, this is my command: take the Temple keys of God and hold on to them until the day the Lord demands them back from you.

5 For we were not found worthy to guard them, because we proved to be faithless stewards."

6 While Jeremiah was still weeping over the people, they were being dragged off to Babylon.[b]

7 Baruch threw dust on his head and sat down, and he sang this lament:[c] "Why has Jerusalem been laid waste?

Because of the sins of the people we love, it was handed over to enemy hands, because of our sins and the sins of the people.

8 But let the lawless ones not boast, saying, 'We had the strength to take God's city by our own power.' You could not do it. It was because of our sins that we were handed over.

9 But our God will have compassion on us and bring us back to our city. You, however, will not live."
10 "Happy are our ancestors Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob: they passed out of this world and never saw this city fall."
11 When he had said this, Baruch went outside the city, weeping and saying, "I grieve on your account, Jerusalem, because I left you."
12 He kept sitting in a burial place, and the angels visited him and made everything clear to him.

Notes

- a (4:4) Addressing the sun, and the earth in chapter 3 above, matches the Bible's way of calling on creation as a witness (compare Deuteronomy 32:1; Isaiah 1:2).
- b (4:6) "Babylon" is the Greek form of Hebrew Bavel, a name sometimes explained as "gate of god" (Akkadian) and linked in Genesis 11:9 to the Hebrew word *balal*, "confuse."
- c (4:7) The Greek word is *thrēnos*, a funeral song or lament, like the Hebrew book of Lamentations.

Chapter 5

1 Abimelech took the figs in the scorching heat and came to a tree; he sat down in its shade to rest for a short while.[a] 2 He leaned his head against the basket of figs and fell asleep. He slept for sixty-six years,[b] and he did not wake from his sleep. 3 Then, waking from his sleep, he said, "That was sweet sleep, but short; my head still feels heavy, since I have not slept my fill." 4 He lifted the cover off the basket of figs and saw that they were still wet, running with a milky sap. 5 He said, "I would like another little sleep, but my head weighs on me. Still, I fear that if I drift off I will wake late, and my father Jeremiah will think ill of me. He would not have sent me out at first light today unless he needed them quickly. 6 So I will get up and go on in the heat, and I will reach the place where there is no scorching heat and no daily weariness."[c] 7 He got up, took the basket of figs, and lifted it onto his shoulder. He went into Jerusalem, and he did not recognize it, or the house, or the place, or anyone from his own family. 8 He said, "May the Lord be praised, since a deep daze has fallen on me! 9 This is not the city! I have lost my way. I came up by the mountain road, and when I woke, my head was so heavy from lack of rest that I wandered

off the path. [10] It will seem remarkable to Jeremiah when I tell him that
I have lost my way." [11] He went out of the city and looked carefully
for the signs of the city, and he said, "This is the city all right, but I
have lost my way." [12] He went into the city again and looked around,
but found no one he knew. He said, "May the Lord be praised, since
a deep daze has fallen on me." [13] He went out of the city again, and
stayed there in distress, not knowing where he should go. [14] He set
the basket down and said, "I will stay seated here until the Lord lifts
this daze off me." [15] As he was sitting there, he saw an old man coming
in from the field. Abimelech said to him, "Look, old man, what city is
this?" [16] He answered him, "It is Jerusalem." [17] Abimelech said to him,
"Where are Jeremiah the priest and Baruch the reader,[d] and all the
people of this city, since I could not find them?" [18] The old man asked
him, "Are you not a native of this city? You mention Jeremiah today,
and you ask after him after so long a time? [19] Jeremiah is in Babylon
with the people, who were carried off by King Nebuchadnezzar,[e] and
he is there with them to announce good news and instruct them in
the word." [20] Abimelech heard the old man out, and answered, "If you
were not so aged, and if it were not improper to rebuke a man who
is older than oneself, I would laugh at you and tell you that you have
lost your mind, for claiming that the people have been carried off to
Babylon. [21] Even if the floodgates of heaven had opened on them, it
would not yet be time to go to Babylon! [22] Why, it was only a short
time ago that my father Jeremiah sent me to Agrippa's estate to fetch
a few figs, which we meant to give to the sick among the people. [23] I
went and picked them, and on reaching a certain tree in the blazing
heat, I sat down for a short rest. I put my head on the basket and
dozed off. [24] When I woke up, I uncovered the basket of figs, thinking
that I had slept too long, and I found the figs dripping with milk, just
as I had gathered them. [25] But you say the people were taken captive
to Babylon. [26] But so that you can know, take the figs and look!" [27] He
lifted the cover of the basket for the old man. [28] When the old man
looked at the figs, he said, "My son, you are a righteous man. God
did not wish you to witness the city's desolation, so he sent this daze
over you. [29] For now it has been sixty-six years since the people were

taken captive to Babylon. 30 So that you can learn, my child, that this is true: look out over the field and see that the crops are springing up.[f] 31 Look also at the figs: it is not their season. Learn from that, and be enlightened." 32 Then Abimelech cried out loudly, saying, "Blessed be God, who gives the souls of the righteous rest in every place!" 33 Then he asked the old man, "What month is this?" 34 He answered, "Nisan[g] (March–April), the twelfth." 35 He took a few of the figs and handed them to the old man, saying, "May God light your path to the Jerusalem above."

Notes

- a (5:1) The Greek says "the heat" (*kauma*), the midday heat of the Judean hills.
- b (5:2) Greek *hexēkonta hex etē*, "sixty-six years"; the same number is repeated in 5:29. Abimelech's long sleep is the main sign in the book that the exile has begun and that years have passed.
- c (5:6) The Greek of this verse is damaged. Harris notes that the manuscripts differ here and that the line is probably corrupt, so the sense given is tentative.
- d (5:17) Greek *anagnōstēs*, "reader" (one who reads the Scriptures aloud); here it names Baruch as Jeremiah's scribe and reader.
- e (5:19) "Nebuchadnezzar" is the Greek form of Babylonian *Nabu-kudurri-usur*, "Nabu, protect my heir" (a common spelling in the Bible is Nebuchadrezzar).
- f (5:30) The Greek reads "the growth of the crops has appeared" (so Harris); some editors emend this to "has not appeared." Either way the point is that the figs are out of season.
- g (5:34) Greek *Nisan*, the Hebrew first month (March–April). Harris notes that Nisan was never the twelfth month, and suggests that "the twelfth" here means the twelfth day of the first month, the day Ezra left the Ahava river for Jerusalem (Ezra 8:31); he also wonders whether the text once read "Nisan, which is Abib" (Abib is the older Hebrew name of the month, Exodus 13:4). The Ethiopic version has "the twelfth of the month Nisan."

Chapter 6

1 Afterward Abimelech left the city and prayed to the Lord. 2 And an angel of the Lord appeared, and set him down at the place where Baruch was; he found him sitting in a tomb. 3 When they saw each other, they embraced and kissed one another. 4 Baruch looked up and saw the figs, still covered over in the basket. 5 Then he raised his eyes toward heaven and prayed: 6 "Lord, you are the God who pays back those who are holy. Prepare yourself, my heart, and be glad

and celebrate inside your tent,[a] and tell your house of flesh that your
sorrow has turned into joy. For the One who is able is on his way, and
he will bring you out of your tent; there is no sin in you. 7 Come to
life again in your dwelling, in my unspoiled faith,[b] and believe that
you will live! 8 Look at this basket of figs: it has been sixty-six years
since they were picked, and they have not withered or rotted; they
are dripping milk. 9 So it will be for you, my flesh, if you carry out
what the angel of righteousness has told you. 10 The one who kept
the basket of figs safe is the same one who will keep you safe again
by his power." 11 After saying this, Baruch turned to Abimelech. "Rise,
and let us pray that the Lord will teach us how we can get word to
Jeremiah in Babylon about the shelter that was given you on your
way." 12 Baruch prayed, "You are our strength, our God and Lord, the
chosen light that has come out of your mouth. 13 We turn to your
goodness and plead with you, whose great Name[c] nobody can know:
listen to the voices of your servants, and let understanding enter our
hearts. 14 What do you want us to do? How can we send word to
Jeremiah in Babylon?" 15 While Baruch was still praying, an angel of
the Lord appeared and spoke to him. "Baruch, helper of the light, do
not worry over how you are to get word to Jeremiah. An eagle will
come to you tomorrow, at the hour of light, and you will send it to
Jeremiah. 16 So put this in the letter: 'Say to the sons of Israel: Anyone
who has become a foreigner among you should be kept apart, and let
fifteen days go by. After that, I will bring you to your own city, says
the Lord. 17 Whoever is not separated from Babylon, Jeremiah, will not
enter the city. I command that they not be taken back again by the
Babylonians, says the Lord.'" 18 When the angel had said this, he left
Baruch. 19 Baruch sent a messenger to the market of the Gentiles, who
returned with papyrus and ink, and Baruch wrote a letter that read:
"From Baruch, servant of God, to Jeremiah in the Babylonian exile. 20
Greetings! Rejoice and be glad, because God did not let us leave this
body in grief over the city that was laid waste and insulted. 21 For this
reason the Lord had compassion on our tears and remembered the
covenant that he made with our fathers Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.[d]
22 He sent his angel to me, who told me these words that I am sending

to you. 23 These are the words of the Lord, the God of Israel, who brought us up from the land of Egypt,[e] from the great furnace:[f] 'You did not keep my laws; your heart grew proud, and you held your necks stiff against me. So in anger and fury I gave you over to the furnace of Babylon. 24 If you will obey my voice, says the Lord, as it comes through Jeremiah my servant, then I will lead the obedient up out of Babylon. But whoever will not obey will be an outsider to Jerusalem and to Babylon alike. 25 You will put them to the test with the water of the Jordan:[g] the one who will not obey will be shown up. That is the sign of the great seal.'"

Notes

- a (6:6) "Tent" translates Greek *skēnōma*, "dwelling," the body, as in 2 Corinthians 5:1 and 2 Peter 1:13; the speaker is preparing his soul for the resurrection of the body he describes next.
- b (6:7) Greek *parthenikē pistis*, literally "virginal faith," meaning a faith not spoiled by any impurity. The manuscripts differ widely in this verse; Harris notes that one of them reads "in your own home, my virginal faith."
- c (6:13) Greek *to mega onoma*, "the great Name"; here it refers to the divine name, which is Yahweh in Hebrew (Exodus 3:14–15). The Greek text does not spell it out.
- d (6:21) "Abraham" (Hebrew *Avraham*) means "father of a multitude" (Genesis 17:5); "Isaac" (*Yitskhaq*) means "he laughs" (Genesis 21:6); "Jacob" (*Ya'aqov*) is linked in Genesis 25:26 to "heel" and means "he grasps the heel," or "he supplants."
- e (6:23) "Egypt" is Greek *Aigyptos*; the Hebrew is *Mitsrayim*, of uncertain meaning.
- f (6:23) The "iron furnace" is the Bible's image for Egypt (Deuteronomy 4:20; 1 Kings 8:51; Jeremiah 11:4).
- g (6:25) "Jordan" (Hebrew *Yarden*) means "the descender," because the river drops steeply from the north to the Dead Sea.

Chapter 7

1 Baruch got up and left the tomb, and he saw an eagle sitting outside the tomb. 2 The eagle answered in a human voice, "Greetings, Baruch, steward of the faith." 3 Baruch said to him, "You who speak this way: you are chosen out of all the birds of heaven, because it shows in the look of your eyes. Tell me what you are doing here." 4 The eagle replied, "I have been sent so that you can use me to carry any word you wish." 5 "Can you take a message to Jeremiah in Babylon?" Baruch asked. 6 The eagle said to him, "Yes; that is the very reason I was sent."

7 Baruch took the letter, together with fifteen figs from Abimelech's
basket, and fastened them around the eagle's neck. "Hear me, king
of the birds," he said. "Go in peace and good health, and bring back
word to me. 8 Do not be like the raven that Noah sent out,[a] which did
not come back to him in the ark. Be like the dove that, after the third
time, brought the news to the righteous man. 9 In the same way, you
also take this good news to Jeremiah and those with him, so that it
will go well with you; take this joy to the chosen people of God. 10
Should every bird in the sky close in around you, and every enemy
of the truth wish to attack you, fight back; the Lord will give you
power. 11 Do not swerve right or left. Fly as straight as a flying arrow,
and travel in the strength of God, who will accompany you the whole
way."[b] 12 The eagle then rose into the air and flew off to Babylon, where
it settled upon a post in a lonely place outside the city. 13 It stayed
silent until Jeremiah came by with some of the people, who were on
their way out of the city to bury a dead body. 14 Jeremiah had asked
Nebuchadnezzar for this: "Give me a place to bury the dead of my
people." And the king had given it to him. 15 As they were coming out,
weeping beside the corpse, they came to the spot opposite the eagle.
16 The eagle cried out loudly, "I say to you, Jeremiah, chosen of God:
go, gather all the people, and let them come here, to hear the letter
I have brought you from Baruch and Abimelech." 17 When Jeremiah
heard this, he glorified God. He went and gathered the people with
their wives and children, and came to the place where the eagle was.
18 The eagle swooped down onto the dead body, and the man was
alive again.[c] 19 This happened so that they would believe. 20 The whole
crowd was astonished at what had taken place. "Is this the God who
showed himself to our ancestors in the wilderness through Moses,[d]
and has now shown himself to us through this great eagle?" they
said. 21 "Jeremiah," the eagle said, "I am speaking to you: loosen this
letter and read it aloud to the people." 22 When the people heard it,
they wept, put dust on their heads, and said to Jeremiah, "Save us,
and tell us what we should do, so that we can enter our city again." 23
Jeremiah answered and said, "Whatever you heard in the letter, keep
it, and he will bring us into our city." 24 Jeremiah also wrote a letter to

Baruch, as follows: "My beloved child, do not slack off in your prayers for us, asking him to set our way straight until we escape from the commands of this lawless king. [25] For you were found righteous before him, and he did not allow you to come here with us, so that you would not see the abuse the people are suffering at the hands of the Babylonians. [26] Think of a father whose only son has been given up to be punished. The bystanders cover the father's face so that he will not watch his son suffer and be crushed by sorrow. [27] In the same way God felt pity for you and kept you from entering Babylon, so that you would not witness the people's sufferings. [28] We have not been free of grief since we arrived here, and today makes sixty-six years. [29] More than once, whenever I went outside, some of the people were hanging there on the orders of King Nebuchadnezzar, wailing, 'Have pity on us, God Zar!'[e] [30] Hearing it, I mourned and wept doubly, not only because they hung there but because they were crying out to a god who was not ours: 'Have pity on us.' [31] But I remembered the days of festival that we used to celebrate in Jerusalem before we were taken into exile; and as I remembered them I groaned, and went back to my house sighing and weeping. [32] So pray now where you are, you and Abimelech, on behalf of this people, asking that they will heed my voice and the rulings of my mouth, and that we may be able to depart from this place. [33] I tell you, all the time we have been here, our captors have been demanding, 'Sing us one of the songs of Zion,[f] a song of your God.' [34] And we answer them, 'How can we sing a song of the Lord on foreign soil?'" [35] Jeremiah then fastened the letter around the eagle's neck and said, "Go in peace; may the Lord guard the two of us." [36] The eagle flew off and came to Baruch, and gave him the letter. He opened it and read it, kissed it, and wept when he heard of the sufferings and troubles of the people. [37] Jeremiah took the figs and distributed them among the sick of the people. He stayed on, teaching them to keep away from the wrongdoing of the gentiles of Babylon.

Notes

- a (7:8) Compare Genesis 8:6–12. In Genesis the raven goes out and is not said to return, and the dove is sent out three times: the second time it returns with an olive leaf, and the third time it does not come back. Here the story is told differently,

and it is the third trip that brings word. "Noah" (*Noach*) is explained in Genesis 5:29 as related to the Hebrew for "comfort."

- b (7:11) At the end of this verse, two of Harris's three manuscript groups (a and b) add: "and the glory of the Lord will be on every road you travel."
- c (7:18) Harris's manuscripts a and b add "and rose up."
- d (7:20) "Moses" (Hebrew *Mosheh*) is explained in Exodus (chapter 2, verse 10) as "drawn out" of the water.
- e (7:29) The manuscripts differ here. Harris prints *Zar*, which he takes to be Hebrew *zar*, "foreign" or "alien"; one of his manuscripts reads *Sabaoth*, and the Ethiopic copies read Zar, Sotoi, or Sarot.
- f (7:33) "Zion" (Hebrew *Tsiyyon*) is the hill of Jerusalem and a poetic name for the city itself; the demand echoes Psalm 137:3.

Chapter 8

1 The day came on which God was bringing the people up out of
Babylon. 2 The Lord told Jeremiah, "Get up, you and the people, and
go to the Jordan. Tell the people: 'Whoever wishes to follow the Lord
must give up the practices of Babylon, including the men who have
taken wives from that land and the women who have taken husbands.
3 If they heed you, take them across to Jerusalem; but if they refuse
to heed you, bring them no farther.'" 4 Jeremiah relayed all of this to
the people, and they got up and went to the Jordan to cross it. 5 As
he told them what the Lord had said to him, half of those who had
married among the Babylonians[a] refused to hear Jeremiah. They said,
"We will not give up our wives for good. We will take them back with
us to our city." 6 They went over the Jordan and reached Jerusalem. 7
Jeremiah, Baruch, and Abimelech stood and said, "Any man who has
had fellowship with the Babylonians will not enter this city!" 8 Then
the others said to one another, "Let us get up and go back to Babylon,
to our own place." And they left. 9 But as they neared Babylon, the
Babylonians came out to confront them. "You may not enter our city,"
they said, "since you despised us and left us in secret. That is why you
cannot come in among us. 10 We have bound ourselves to each other by
oath, in the name of our God, to take in neither you nor your children,
since you slipped away from us." 11 Hearing this, they turned around
and traveled to an empty region well away from Jerusalem. There
they founded a city of their own and called it Samaria.[b] 12 Jeremiah

sent a message to them: “Turn back, for the angel of righteousness is on his way, and he will take you to your lofty home.”

Notes

- a (8:5) Greek *Babylōnitai*, “Babylonians,” inhabitants of Babylon; the book pictures marriages between exiles and local people in Babylon.
- b (8:11) “Samaria” (Hebrew *Shomron*) was the capital of the northern kingdom (1 Kings 16:24), named after the hill’s owner Shemer. The book’s closing story gives Samaria’s origin as a town of the exiles who were turned away from Jerusalem because of mixed marriages, a way of explaining the later hostility between Jews and Samaritans.

Chapter 9

1 Those who were with Jeremiah[a] rejoiced and offered a sacrifice for
the people nine days. 2 On the tenth day, Jeremiah offered a sacrifice
by himself. 3 He started to pray: “Holy, holy, holy, incense of the living
trees, true light shining on me, until I rise up to you. 4 I ask you, too, for
the sweet sound of the two Seraphim,[b] and for yet another fragrance
of incense. 5 My concern is Michael,[c] the archangel of righteousness,
[who opens the gates of righteousness] until he brings the righteous
in. 6 I plead with you, Lord, almighty over all creation, the One who
was never born and cannot be fully known, in whom all judgment lay
hidden before these things came to be.” 7 While Jeremiah was saying
this, standing at the altar with Baruch and Abimelech, he became like
someone giving up his soul. 8 Baruch and Abimelech stayed where
they were, weeping and shouting at the top of their voices: “Our
father Jeremiah has left us! God’s priest is gone!” 9 All the people
heard the sound of their weeping, and everyone ran to them, and they
saw Jeremiah lying on the ground as though dead. 10 They ripped their
clothes, threw dust on their heads, and sobbed in bitter grief. 11 After
this, they got ready to bury him. 12 Then a voice said, “Do not bury
the man who is still alive, because his soul is coming back into his
body.” 13 They obeyed the voice and did not bury him. For three days
they waited by his tent, asking, “When will he get up?” 14 Three days
later his soul returned to his body. Standing among all of them, he
cried out, “All of you, praise God! Praise God, and praise the Son of
God, who rouses you toward Jesus Christ,[d] the light of every age, the

lamp that cannot be put out, the life of faith." 15 "After these times, there will come four hundred seventy-seven more years,[e] and he will come to the earth. 16 The tree of life planted in the middle of paradise will make all the unfruitful trees bear fruit,[f] and they will grow and sprout. 17 As for the trees that have sprouted and grown proud, and say, 'We gave our strength to the air,' he will make them wither, along with the height of their branches, and will have them judged by that firmly planted tree. 18 The crimson will turn white as wool, the snow will darken, and sweet waters will turn salty,[g] in the great light of God's joy. 19 He will bless the islands and make them fruitful through the word that comes from his Anointed One's mouth. 20 For he himself will come and go forth, and choose twelve apostles for himself, to carry the good news among the nations. I saw him, adorned by his Father, as he entered the world, at the Mount of Olives,[h] and he will fill souls that hunger." 21 While Jeremiah was saying this about the Son of God, the people became angry and said, "These are once again the words that Isaiah son of Amoz[i] spoke, when he said, 'I saw God and the Son of God.' 22 Come, let us not put him to death the way we did Isaiah,[j] but let us throw stones at him." 23 Baruch and Abimelech were deeply grieved at this absence, and because they wanted to hear fully the things that he had seen. 24 But Jeremiah said to them, "Be quiet and do not weep, for they cannot kill me until I have told you everything I saw." 25 And he said to them, "Bring me a stone." They brought a stone to him. 26 He stood it up and prayed, "Light of the ages, let this stone take on my likeness until I have told Baruch and Abimelech all that I saw." 27 So, at God's order, the stone took on Jeremiah's likeness. 28 And they were stoning the stone, thinking that it was Jeremiah. 29 But Jeremiah handed over all the mysteries that he had seen to Baruch and Abimelech, and then he stood up in the middle of the people, wishing to carry out his commission. 30 The stone cried out, "You foolish sons of Israel, why are you stoning me, thinking that I am Jeremiah? Look, Jeremiah is standing in your midst!" 31 When they saw him, they ran at him right away with many stones, and his commission was fulfilled. 32 Baruch and Abimelech came and buried

him, and they took the stone and set it on his tomb, and they inscribed on it, “This stone is the helper of Jeremiah.”[k]

Notes

- a (9:1) The Greek verb at the start of this verse is awkward in the printed text (it literally means “begot”), and the sense here, taken from the context, is that Jeremiah’s followers were celebrating.
- b (9:4) “Seraphim” (Hebrew *seraphim*, “burning ones”) are the winged beings around God’s throne in Isaiah 6:2–3; the Ethiopic version appears to read “Cherubim” here instead.
- c (9:5) “Michael” (Hebrew *Mikha’el*) means “Who is like God?” The words in brackets are not in the Greek printed by Harris; they come from the Ethiopic version, which has Michael hold the gates of righteousness open.
- d (9:14) The Greek words “Jesus Christ” are in Harris’s text, and scholars debate whether these two words were added by a Christian hand to an originally Jewish text. “Christ” is Greek *Christos*, “anointed,” the equivalent of Hebrew *mashiach*, “messiah.”
- e (9:15) This is the number in Greek manuscripts a and b; the Ethiopic counts in “weeks of days,” with a figure of 303 (some copies 330 or 333).
- f (9:16) Harris’s manuscripts a and b omit the clause that follows in the Ethiopic: “and their fruit will remain with the angels.”
- g (9:18) The Ethiopic adds “and the salty waters will become sweet.”
- h (9:20) The Mount of Olives is the ridge east of Jerusalem (Zechariah 14:4; Mark 13:3). The Greek reads *Elaiōn*, “of the olive trees.”
- i (9:21) “Isaiah” (Hebrew *Yeshayahu*) means “Yahweh saves”; “Amoz” (*Amots*) means “strong.” The Greek text spells his father’s name “Amos.”
- j (9:22) An old Jewish tradition, preserved in the *Martyrdom of Isaiah* and probably referred to in Hebrews 11:37, says that Isaiah was sawn in two.
- k (9:32) Harris’s manuscripts a and b add a closing sentence saying that the rest of Jeremiah’s words and every aspect of his power are not written here but in the letter of Baruch.

Testaments of the Twelve Patriarchs

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

The Testament of Reuben, on the Thoughts of the Mind

Chapter 1 (verses 1–10 here) 1 A copy of the testament of Reuben:[a] the
things he charged his sons with before his death, in the hundred and
twenty-fifth year of his life. 2 Two years after Joseph's death he fell
ill, and his sons and his sons' sons gathered to visit him. 3 He said to
them, "My little children, I am dying, and I am setting out on the road
my fathers took." 4 Seeing Judah, Gad and Asher, his brothers, there,
he said to them, "Prop me up, brothers, so I can tell my brothers and
my children the things I keep hidden in my heart, since from now
on I am fading." 5 He got up, kissed them, wept, and said, "Listen, my
brothers; turn your ears, all of you, to Reuben your father and to what
I command you. 6 Look: today I call the God of heaven as witness
against you, so that you do not go the way of youthful ignorance and
sexual immorality, the thing I poured myself out in when I defiled my
father Jacob's bed.[b] 7 I tell you, he struck me with a heavy blow in my
loins for seven months, and if Jacob our father had not prayed to the
Lord for me, the Lord was minded to make an end of me. 8 I was thirty
years old when I did that evil thing in the Lord's sight, and for seven
months I lay sick almost to death. 9 Then, by the free choice of my
soul, I repented before the Lord for seven years. 10 Wine and strong
drink I did not drink; meat did not enter my mouth; no bread I craved
did I taste. I mourned over my sin, for it was great. Nothing like it
will ever be done in Israel."

Chapter 2 (verses 11–19 here) 11 "Now hear me, children, about what
I saw during my repentance concerning the seven spirits of deceit. 12
Seven spirits are given against humankind from Beliar,[c] and they are

the head of the deeds of youthful rashness. 13 Seven other spirits were
given to a person at creation, so that every human work might be
done by them. 14 The first is the spirit of life, with which the human
frame is built. The second is the spirit of sight, which gives rise to
desire. 15 The third is the spirit of hearing, which gives rise to teaching.
The fourth is the spirit of smell, to which taste is joined for drawing
in air and breath. 16 The fifth is the spirit of speech, which gives rise to
knowledge. 17 The sixth is the spirit of taste, which gives rise to eating
food and drink, and by it strength is built up, since strength rests on
food. 18 The seventh is the spirit of seed and intercourse, with which,
through love of pleasure, sin comes in as well. 19 That is why it is the
last in creation and the first in youth: it is full of ignorance, and it
leads the young man like a blind man into a pit and like a beast over
a cliff."

Chapter 3 (verses 20–34 here) 20 "On top of all these there is an eighth,
the spirit of sleep, with which was created the trance of nature, the
image of death. 21 With these spirits the spirit of deceit mingles. 22
First, the spirit of sexual immorality, seated in nature and the senses.
Second, the spirit of gluttony, in the belly. 23 Third, the spirit of fight-
ing, in the liver and the gall. Fourth, the spirit of fawning and trickery,
so that by fussing over himself a man may seem handsome. 24 Fifth, the
spirit of arrogance, so that he may strut and think big. Sixth, the spirit
of lying, in ruin and jealousy, so that he invents stories even to family
and household. 25 Seventh, the spirit of injustice, with which come
theft and grasping, so that he may serve his heart's love of pleasure;
for injustice works hand in hand with the other spirits through taking
bribes.[d] 26 On top of all these the spirit of sleep, the eighth spirit, is
joined to deceit and illusion. 27 So every young man is lost, darkening
his mind away from the truth, not understanding the law of God
and not heeding the warnings of his fathers, just as I suffered in my
youth. 28 And now, children, love the truth, and it will guard you. I am
teaching you: listen to Reuben your father. 29 Do not fix your attention
on a woman's looks, do not be alone with a married woman, and do
not busy yourselves with women's affairs. 30 If I had not seen Bilhah[e]
bathing in a sheltered place, I would not have fallen into that great

lawlessness. 31 My mind took in the woman's nakedness and would
not let me sleep until I had done the abomination. 32 For while Jacob
our father was away with Isaac his father, and we were in Gader,[f]
near Ephrath,[g] that is, Bethlehem, Bilhah was drunk and lay asleep,
uncovered, in her bedroom. 33 I went in, saw her nakedness, and did
the impious thing; then I left her sleeping and went out. 34 At once an
angel of God revealed my impiety to my father Jacob. He came and
mourned over me, and he never touched her again."

Chapter 4 (verses 35–45 here) 35 "So do not fix your attention on
women's beauty, and do not brood on what they do. Walk in single-
ness of heart, in the fear of the Lord, laboring at your work, letting
your mind roam among books and among your flocks, until the Lord
gives you the wife he wills, so that you do not suffer as I did. 36
Until our father's death I did not have the nerve to look Jacob in the
face or to speak to any of my brothers, because of the reproaches.
37 And to this day my conscience grips me over my sin. 38 Yet my
father comforted me, for he had prayed to the Lord for me that the
Lord's anger might pass from me, as the Lord showed me. From then
on I kept careful watch, and I did not sin. 39 So, my children, keep
everything I command you, and you will not sin. 40 Sexual immorality
is the ruin of the soul. It separates from God and brings near to
idols, because it is what misleads the mind and understanding, and it
brings young men down to Hades before their time. 41 It has destroyed
many. Even if a man is old or nobly born, it makes him a disgrace
and a laughingstock before Beliar and the children of men. 42 Because
Joseph kept himself from every woman and cleansed his thoughts of
all immorality, he found favor with the Lord and with people. 43 The
Egyptian woman did a great deal to him: she called in sorcerers and
brought him potions. But the counsel of his soul would not take in
evil desire. 44 So the God of my fathers rescued him from every death,
seen and hidden. 45 If immorality does not overpower your thinking,
neither will Beliar overpower you."

Chapter 5 (verses 46–52 here) 46 "Women are evil, my children:[h] because
they have no authority or strength over a man, they scheme with
outward show, how they may draw him to themselves. 47 And the man

a woman cannot overpower by strength she overpowers by deceit. 48 Indeed the angel of God told me about them and taught me that women are more easily overcome by the spirit of immorality than a man is. In their heart they plot against men; by adornment they first lead their minds astray, by a glance they sow the poison, and then by the act they take them captive. 49 For a woman cannot force a man. 50 So flee immorality, my children, and instruct your wives and daughters not to adorn their heads and faces, because every woman who schemes by these means is kept for everlasting punishment. 51 That is how they bewitched the Watchers[i] before the flood. Those Watchers kept looking at them, came to desire them, conceived the act in their minds, and changed themselves into the shape of men; and when the women lay with their husbands, the Watchers appeared with them. 52 The women, longing in their minds for these apparitions, bore giants; for the Watchers appeared to them reaching up to heaven."

Chapter 6 (verses 53–64 here) 53 "So guard yourselves against immorality. If you want to stay pure in mind, guard your senses from every woman. 54 And instruct the women not to keep company with men, so that they too may stay pure in mind. 55 Constant meetings, even if the impious act is never done, are an incurable sickness for them, and for us an everlasting disgrace from Beliar. 56 For immorality has neither understanding nor piety in it, and every jealousy lives in its desire. 57 Therefore you will be jealous of the sons of Levi and seek to be raised above them, but you will not be able to. 58 God will avenge them, and you will die an evil death. 59 For the Lord gave the rule to Levi, and to Judah, and with them to me, and to Dan and Joseph, to be rulers.[j] 60 That is why I command you to listen to Levi: he will know the Lord's law and will make rulings for justice and for sacrifices on behalf of all Israel until the completion of the times of the anointed high priest,[k] of whom the Lord has spoken. 61 I adjure you by the God of heaven: each of you deal truly with his neighbor. 62 Draw near to Levi in humility of heart, so that you may receive a blessing from his mouth. 63 For he will bless Israel and Judah, since it is in him that the Lord has chosen to reign over all the peoples. 64 Bow down to his

offspring, for he will die for us in wars seen and unseen, and he will be among you an eternal king."[l]

Chapter 7 (verses 65–66 here) 65 Then Reuben died, having given these commands to his sons. 66 They placed him in a coffin until they carried him up from Egypt and buried him in Hebron,[m] in the double cave,[n] where his fathers lay.

Notes

- a (1:1) "Reuben" is explained in Gen 29:32 by a wordplay on "Yahweh has seen my affliction"; the name itself looks like "See, a son!" (Hebrew re'u ben). The meaning is uncertain. In the Greek the name is spelled Roubēm, as often in the Septuagint. Verses in this book are numbered straight through each testament; the subheads give the traditional chapter divisions of Charles's 1908 Greek edition, so "verse 12 here" can be matched with the usual chapter-and-verse reference.
- b (1:6) See Gen 35:22; 49:4. "Poured myself out" echoes Gen 49:4, "unstable as water."
- c (1:12) Beliar (Hebrew Belial, "worthlessness"; the derivation is debated) is the usual name for the chief evil power in the Testaments.
- d (1:25) The Greek word (dolēpsia, here spelled dololēpsia) is rare; "taking bribes" or "crafty grabbing" are both possible.
- e (1:30) Greek Balla, for Hebrew Bilhah, Rachel's maid and Jacob's concubine (Gen 30:3–4). The meaning of the name is uncertain; "timid" and "carefree" have both been suggested.
- f (1:32) Gader corresponds to "Eder" (Migdal Eder, "tower of the flock") in Gen 35:21.
- g (1:32) Ephrath ("fruitful," if from the root p-r-h; uncertain) is identified with Bethlehem ("house of bread") in Gen 35:19.
- h (1:46) The harsh generalizations about women in 5:1–5 belong to the outlook of the writer and are translated as they stand.
- i (1:51) The Watchers are the fallen angels of Gen 6:1–4 as retold in 1 Enoch 6–16. Here, unusually, the women are blamed.
- j (1:59) The Greek is obscure here; some witnesses read differently. The point is that Levi and Judah hold the leading place.
- k (1:60) Greek archiereōs christou, "of an anointed high priest" or "of Christ the high priest." Charles took the line as Jewish, referring to a Hasmonean priest-king; others (e.g., de Jonge) read the whole work as Christian in its present form. See the introduction.
- l (1:64) "He will die for us" may be a Christian touch; the referent ("his offspring") is ambiguous between Levi's line and Judah's.
- m (1:66) Hebron perhaps means "association" or "league" (from the root h-b-r); uncertain.

- n (1:66) The cave of Machpelah (Gen 23:9, 19); the Septuagint renders Machpelah as "the double cave."

Chapter 2

The Testament of Simeon, on Envy

Chapter 1 (verses 1–2 here) 1 A copy of the words of Simeon,[a] which he spoke to his sons before he died, in the hundred and twentieth year of his life, the year in which Joseph died. 2 His sons had come to visit him in his illness, and he gathered his strength and sat up, kissed them, and said to them,

Chapter 2 (verses 3–16 here) 3 "Listen, children, listen to Simeon your father, about everything I carry in my heart. 4 I was born to my father Jacob as his second son, and Leah[b] my mother called me Simeon, because the Lord heard her prayer. 5 I became very strong; I shrank from no task and was afraid of nothing. 6 My heart was hard, my liver unmoved, my insides without pity, 7 for courage, too, is given to people by the Most High, in soul and in body. 8 At that time I was jealous of Joseph, because our father loved him, 9 and I steeled my liver to kill him. The ruler of deceit sent the spirit of jealousy and blinded my mind, so that I did not look on him as a brother and did not spare Jacob my father. 10 But his God, the God of his fathers, sent His angel and rescued him from my hands. 11 For while I was away in Shechem[c] fetching ointment for the flocks, and Reuben was at Dothan,[d] where our supplies and all our stores were, our brother Judah sold him to the Ishmaelites.[e] 12 When Reuben came back he was grieved, for he had wanted to bring him safely to his father. 13 I was angry with Judah because he had let him go alive, and I stayed angry with him for five months. 14 Even so, God held me back and kept my hands from their work, for my right hand was half withered for seven days. 15 I knew, children, that this had come on me because of Joseph. I repented and wept, and I prayed to the Lord to restore my hand, so that I might keep away from all defilement, envy, and folly. 16 For I knew that I had planned an evil thing before the Lord and Jacob my father, through envying my brother Joseph."

Chapter 3 (verses 17–22 here) [17] "Now, children, beware of the spirits of deceit and envy. [18] Envy rules the whole mind of a person and lets him neither eat nor drink nor do anything good. [19] It always urges him to destroy the one he envies; the envied person is always in bloom, while the envier withers. [20] For two years I afflicted my soul with fasting in the fear of the Lord, and I learned that the release from envy comes through the fear of God. [21] If someone runs to the Lord for refuge, the evil spirit runs away from him, and his mind becomes light. [22] From then on he feels with the one he envied, and does not condemn those who love him, and so his envy stops."

Chapter 4 (verses 23–31 here) [23] "My father kept asking about me, because he saw me gloomy, and I said, 'My liver aches.' [24] I mourned more than all the others, because I was to blame for the selling of Joseph. [25] When we went down to Egypt and he bound me as a spy, I knew I was suffering justly, and I did not grieve. [26] Joseph was a good man, with the spirit of God in him, tender-hearted and merciful. He held no grudge against me, but loved me as he loved the other brothers. [27] So beware, my children, of all jealousy and envy, and walk in simplicity of soul and in a good heart, keeping in mind your father's brother, so that God may give you also grace, glory, and blessing on your heads, as you saw in him. [28] All his days he never reproached us about this matter, but loved us as his own soul, more than his own sons. He gave us glory, and granted us all riches, cattle, and crops. [29] You also, my dear children, should each love his brother with a good heart, and drive the spirit of envy out of you, [30] for it makes the soul savage and ruins the body. It brings anger and war to the mind, stirs it up to bloodshed, drives the mind out of its senses, and does not let people use their understanding. It even takes away sleep, and brings turmoil to the soul and trembling to the body. [31] Even in sleep, a jealous malice shows itself in dreams and eats the person up; with evil spirits it disturbs his soul, makes his body shake with fear, and wakes his mind in confusion. He looks to others like someone who has an evil, venomous spirit."

Chapter 5 (verses 32–37 here) [32] "That is why Joseph was handsome in form and fair to look at: no evil lived in him. For the face shows

what the spirit is stirred by. 33 Now, my children, make your hearts
good before the Lord, and make your ways straight before people,
and you will find favor with God and people. 34 Guard against sexual
immorality, for it is the mother of all evils; it separates people from
God and brings them near to Beliar. 35 I have seen in the writing of
Enoch[f] that your sons, along with you, will be corrupted by sexual
immorality, and will do wrong against Levi with the sword. 36 But they
will not be able to stand against Levi, because he will fight the Lord's
war and will defeat all your camps. 37 You will be few in number,
divided up among Levi and Judah, and no one of yours will hold rule,
just as my father Jacob prophesied in his blessings."

Chapter 6 (verses 38–44 here) 38 "See, I have told you everything
beforehand, so that I am cleared of the sin of your souls. 39 If you
remove envy and all stubbornness from you, my bones will blossom
like a rose in Israel, and my flesh like a lily in Jacob. My fragrance
will be like the fragrance of Lebanon, and holy cedars will multiply
from me forever, and their branches will stretch far. 40 Then the seed
of Canaan[g] will perish, and nothing will be left of Amalek;[h] all the
Cappadocians will be destroyed, and all the Hittites will be wiped
out. 41 Then the land of Ham[i] will fail and all its people will perish.
Then the whole earth will rest from turmoil, and everything under
heaven from war. 42 Then Shem[j] will be glorified, for the Lord God,
the great one of Israel, will appear on the earth as a human being
and save Adam[k] in him. 43 Then all the spirits of deceit will be handed
over to be trampled, and people will rule over the evil spirits. 44 Then
I will rise in joy and bless the Most High for His wonders, because
God took a body, ate with humans, and saved them."

Chapter 7 (verses 45–47 here) 45 "Now, my little children, obey Levi,
and in Judah you will be set free. Do not exalt yourselves over these
two tribes, for from them the salvation of God will rise for you. 46 The
Lord will raise up from Levi a high priest, and from Judah a king,
God and man. In this way He will save all the nations and the family
of Israel. 47 For this reason I command you everything, so that you
also may command your children, and they may keep these things
through their generations."

Chapter 8 (verses 48–51 here) [48] Simeon finished commanding his sons and fell asleep with his fathers, at the age of a hundred and twenty. [49] They laid him in a coffin of incorruptible wood, to carry his bones up to Hebron. They carried them up secretly during a war with the Egyptians. [50] For the Egyptians were guarding the bones of Joseph in the treasuries of the palace. [51] Their sorcerers had told them that when Joseph's bones left, there would be darkness and gloom over all Egypt and a very great plague on the Egyptians, so that people would not recognize their own brothers even with a lamp.

Chapter 9 (verse 52 here) [52] Simeon's sons mourned their father according to the custom of mourning, and they stayed in Egypt until the day they left Egypt, under Moses.[l]

Notes

- a (2:1) "Simeon" (Hebrew *Shimon*) is explained in Gen 29:33 by a wordplay on "heard," as in "Yahweh has heard." In the Greek the name is spelled Symeon.
- b (2:4) "Leah" (Hebrew *Le'ah*) is of uncertain meaning; it may mean "wild cow" or "weary."
- c (2:11) "Shechem" (Hebrew *Shekhem*) means "shoulder" or "ridge." The city stood in the hill country of Ephraim.
- d (2:11) "Dothan" (Hebrew *Dothan*) is a town north of Shechem.
- e (2:11) "Ishmaelites" are descendants of Ishmael, Abraham's son, "God hears"; in Gen 37:25-28 they are the traders to whom Joseph is sold.
- f (2:35) "Enoch" (Hebrew *Chanokh*) is explained as "dedicated" or "trained." The writings ascribed to him are the books of 1 Enoch; the passage meant here is not found in the surviving texts.
- g (2:40) "Canaan" (Hebrew *Kena'an*) is the land west of the Jordan and the name of its people; in Gen 9:25 Canaan is the son of Ham who is cursed.
- h (2:40) "Amalek" (Hebrew *Amaleq*) is the desert people who attacked Israel at Rephidim (Exod 17:8-16) and were long treated as the model enemy.
- i (2:41) "Ham" (Hebrew *Cham*) is one of Noah's sons, whose line included Egypt and Canaan; the name may mean "hot" or "dark."
- j (2:42) "Shem" (Hebrew *Shem*) means "name." He is the ancestor of the Semitic peoples, including Israel.
- k (2:42) "Adam" (Hebrew *adam*) means "human being," from the word for the ground, *adamah*. The line "save Adam in him" may be a Christian touch.
- l (2:52) "Moses" (Hebrew *Mosheh*) is linked in Exod 2:10 with "drawing out." He led Israel out of Egypt.

Chapter 3

The Testament of Levi, on the Priesthood and Pride

Chapter 1 (verses 1–2 here) 1 A copy of the words of Levi,[a] everything
he laid down for his sons, all that they should do and all that would
happen to them until the day of judgment. 2 He was in good health
when he called them to him, though it had been revealed to him that
he was about to die. When they had gathered, he said to them,
Chapter 2 (verses 3–14 here) 3 "I, Levi, was conceived in Haran[b] and
born there, and afterward I came with my father to Shechem. 4 I was
quite young, about twenty years old, when, together with Simeon,
I took vengeance on Hamor[c] for our sister Dinah.[d] 5 While we were
shepherding in Abelmaul,[e] a spirit of the Lord's understanding came
on me, and I saw all people ruining their way, and I saw that injustice
had built walls for itself, and lawlessness sat on towers. 6 I grieved
over the human race and prayed to the Lord that I might be saved. 7
Then sleep fell on me, and I saw a high mountain. This is Mount Aspis
in Abelmaul. 8 The heavens were opened, and an angel of God said to
me, 'Levi, come in.' 9 I went from the first heaven into the second, and
there I saw water hanging between the one and the other. 10 I saw a
third heaven, far brighter than the two, for it had a boundless height.
11 I said to the angel, 'Why is this?' and the angel said to me, 'Do not be
amazed at these things, for you will see four other heavens, brighter
and beyond comparison, when you go up there. 12 You will stand near
the Lord and be His servant, and you will announce His mysteries to
people and proclaim the one who will redeem Israel. 13 Through you
and Judah the Lord will be seen among people, saving in them every
kind of human being. 14 Your life comes from the Lord's portion, and
He will be your field, vineyard, crops, gold, and silver.'"
Chapter 3 (verses 15–24 here) 15 "'Listen, then, about the seven heavens.
The lowest is gloomier than the rest because it is closest to all the
injustice of people. 16 The second has fire, snow, and ice, ready for the
day of the Lord's command, in the righteous judgment of God. In it
are all the spirits of the punishments, sent to take vengeance on the
lawless. 17 In the third are the powers of the armies, appointed for the
day of judgment, to take vengeance on the spirits of deceit and on

Beliar. Those in the fourth, above these, are holy, [18] for in the highest of all the great Glory lives, in the Holy of Holies, above all holiness. [19] In the one below it are the angels of the Lord's presence, who serve and make atonement before the Lord for all the sins of ignorance of the righteous. [20] They offer to the Lord a pleasing fragrance, a spiritual offering without blood. [21] In the one under that are the angels who carry the answers to the angels of the Lord's presence. [22] In the one after that are thrones and powers, where hymns are always offered to God. [23] So when the Lord looks down on us, all of us are shaken. The heavens, the earth, and the depths shake before the face of His majesty, [24] but the sons of men, unaware of these things, sin and provoke the Most High.'"

Chapter 4 (verses 25–30 here) [25] "'Know now that the Lord will bring judgment on the sons of men. When the rocks are split, the sun is put out, the waters dry up, the fire shrinks back, all creation is shaken, the unseen spirits melt, and Hades is plundered at the suffering of the Most High, people will not believe and will stay in their injustices; for this reason they will be judged with punishment. [26] The Most High has heard your prayer, that you be separated from injustice and become a son, servant, and minister of His presence. [27] You will shine the bright light of knowledge in Jacob, and you will be like the sun for all the seed of Israel. [28] Blessing will be given to you and to all your seed, until the Lord visits all the nations, in the compassion of His Son, forever. Yet your sons will lay hands on Him to hang Him on a pole. [29] For this reason counsel and understanding have been given to you, so that you may teach your sons about Him, [30] because whoever blesses Him will be blessed, and those who curse Him will perish.'"

Chapter 5 (verses 31–37 here) [31] "The angel opened the gates of heaven for me, and I saw the holy temple, and the Most High on a throne of glory. [32] He said to me, 'Levi, I have given you the blessings of the priesthood, until I come and live among Israel.' [33] Then the angel brought me to the earth and gave me a shield and a sword and said, 'Take vengeance at Shechem for Dinah, and I will be with you, for the Lord has sent me.' [34] At that time I finished off the sons of Hamor, as it is written on the tablets of heaven. [35] I said to him, 'I beg you, Lord, tell

me Your name, so that I may call on You in the day of trouble.' [36] He said, 'I am the angel who pleads for the nation of Israel, so that they will not be struck down completely, because every evil spirit attacks them.' [37] After this I woke, as if I had been asleep, and blessed the Most High and the angel who pleads for the nation of Israel and for all the righteous."

Chapter 6 (verses 38–48 here) [38] "As I was on my way to my father, I found a bronze shield; that is why the mountain's name is Aspis, because it is near Gebal, to the right of Abila. [39] I kept these words in my heart. [40] I advised my father, and my brother Reuben, to tell the sons of Hamor that they must be circumcised, because I was zealous over the abomination they had done in Israel. [41] I killed Shechem first, and Simeon killed Hamor. [42] After that my brothers came and struck the city with the edge of the sword. [43] Our father heard of it and was angry and grieved, because they had accepted circumcision and afterward been killed, and in his blessings he spoke of us differently. [44] We had sinned, for we had done this against his judgment, and he became ill that day. [45] But I saw that God had pronounced evil against Shechem, because they wanted to do to Sarah what they had done to our sister Dinah, and the Lord stopped them. [46] In the same way they had persecuted Abraham our father when he was a foreigner, trampled his flocks when they swelled in number around him, and treated Jebla,[f] who was born in his household, savagely. [47] This is how they treated all foreigners, seizing their wives by force and driving the strangers out. [48] But the Lord's wrath overtook them to the end."

Chapter 7 (verses 49–52 here) [49] "I said to my father, 'Do not be angry, sir, for through you the Lord will humble the Canaanites and give their land to you and your seed after you. [50] From today Shechem will be called a city of fools, for as one mocks a fool, so we have mocked them, [51] because they also did a foolish thing in Israel, defiling our sister.' [52] We took our sister from there, set out, and came to Bethel.[g]"

Chapter 8 (verses 53–71 here) [53] "There again I saw a vision like the earlier one, after we had spent seventy days. [54] I saw seven men in white clothing who said to me, 'Get up, put on the robe of the priesthood, the crown of righteousness, the breastpiece of understanding,

the long robe of truth, the plate of faith, the turban of the sign, and the ephod of prophecy.' [55] Each of them carried one of these things and put it on me, and they said, 'From now on be a priest of the Lord, you and your seed, forever.' [56] The first anointed me with holy oil and gave me a staff of judgment. [57] The second washed me with pure water and fed me bread and wine, the holiest of holy things, and put a holy and glorious robe on me. [58] The third clothed me in fine linen, like an ephod. [59] The fourth put a belt on me like purple. [60] The fifth gave me a branch of rich olive. [61] The sixth put a wreath on my head. [62] The seventh put a priestly diadem on my head and filled my hands with incense, so that I could serve as priest to the Lord. [63] They said to me, 'Levi, your seed will be divided into three offices, as a sign of the glory of the Lord who is to come. [64] The one who believes will be first, and no portion greater than his will be given. [65] The second will be in the priesthood. [66] The third will be given a new name, because a king will rise from Judah and set up a new priesthood, after the pattern of the nations, for all the nations. [67] His coming will be beyond words, as of a high prophet from the seed of Abraham our father. [68] Everything desirable in Israel will belong to you and to your seed. You will eat everything beautiful to see, and your seed will share out the Lord's table. [69] From them will come high priests, judges, and scribes, for the holy place will be guarded by their word.' [70] I woke up and understood that this was like the earlier vision. [71] I hid this also in my heart and told it to no one on earth."

Chapter 9 (verses 72–85 here) [72] "Two days later Judah and I went up to Isaac, following our father. [73] My father's father blessed me according to all the words of the visions I had seen, but he did not want to go with us to Bethel. [74] When we came to Bethel, my father Jacob saw in a vision about me that I would be a priest to God for them. [75] He got up early in the morning and paid a tenth of everything to the Lord through me. [76] We came to Hebron to stay there. [77] Isaac called me constantly to remind me of the Lord's law, as the angel of God had shown me. [78] He taught me the law of the priesthood, of sacrifices, whole burnt offerings, firstfruits, freewill offerings, and peace offerings. [79] Each day he instructed me and was busy with me before the

Lord. [80] He said, ‘Child, beware of the spirit of sexual immorality. It will persist, and through your seed it is going to defile the holy things. [81] So take a wife for yourself while still young, one without blemish or defilement, who is not from the family of foreigners or nations. [82] Before you enter the holy things, bathe; while you sacrifice, wash; and when you finish the sacrifice, wash again. [83] Offer to the Lord from twelve trees that always have leaves, as Abraham also taught me. [84] From every clean animal and clean bird offer a sacrifice to the Lord. [85] From every firstfruit and from wine offer firstfruits, and salt every sacrifice.’”

Chapter 10 (verses 86–90 here) [86] “Now keep what I command you, children, because what I heard from my fathers I have told you. [87] I am innocent of all your ungodliness and transgression, which you will commit at the end of the ages against the Savior of the world, being ungodly, leading Israel astray, and stirring up great evils against it from the Lord. [88] You will act lawlessly along with Israel, so that Jerusalem will not be able to bear your wickedness, and the veil of the temple will be torn, so that it no longer covers your shame. [89] You will be scattered as captives among the nations and become a reproach and something to be trampled. [90] For the house the Lord chooses will be called Jerusalem, as the book of Enoch the righteous contains.”

Chapter 11 (verses 91–98 here) [91] “When I took a wife, I was twenty-eight years old. Her name was Milcah.[h] [92] She conceived and bore a son and called his name Gershom,[i] because we were sojourners in our land. For “Gershom” is written to mean “sojourning.” [93] I saw about him that he would not be in the first rank. [94] Kohath[j] was born in my thirty-fifth year, toward sunrise. [95] In a vision I saw him standing in the middle, on high, over the whole assembly. [96] For this reason I called his name Kohath, which means beginning of majesty and gathering. [97] She bore me Merari[k] in the fortieth year of my life. Because his mother had a hard labor, she called him Merari, which means “my bitterness,” because he too died. [98] Jochebed[l] was born in the sixty-fourth year, in Egypt, for I was honored then among my brothers.”

Chapter 12 (verses 99–105 here) [99] “Gershom took a wife and she bore him Libni and Shimei. [100] The sons of Kohath were Amram, Izhar,

Hebron, and Uzziel. [101] The sons of Merari were Mahli and Mushi. [102] In my ninety-fourth year, Amram took my daughter Jochebed as his wife, for they were born on the same day, he and my daughter. [103] I was eight years old when I entered the land of Canaan, eighteen when I killed Shechem, nineteen when I became a priest, twenty-eight when I took a wife, and forty when I went into Egypt. [104] See, you are my children, my children, the third generation. [105] Joseph died in his hundred and eighteenth year."

Chapter 13 (verses 106–114 here) [106] "Now, my children, I command you to fear our Lord with your whole heart and to walk in simplicity according to all His law. [107] Teach your children to read, too, so that they will have understanding all their lives, reading the law of God without ceasing. [108] For everyone who knows the law of God will be honored, and will not be a stranger wherever he goes. [109] He will gain many friends beyond his own parents, and many people will want to serve him and to hear the law from his mouth. [110] Do righteousness, my children, on the earth, so that you may find it in the heavens. [111] Sow good things in your souls, so that you find them in your lives. If you sow evil, you will reap every trouble and distress. [112] Gain wisdom in the fear of God, with diligence. For if there is captivity, and cities and lands are destroyed, and gold and silver and every possession are lost, no one can take away a wise person's wisdom, except the blindness of ungodliness and the crippling of sin. [113] It will shine for him even among his enemies, in a foreign land he will find it a homeland, and in the midst of enemies he will be found a friend. [114] If he teaches these things and does them, he will sit on the throne with a king, as our brother Joseph did."

Chapter 14 (verses 115–122 here) [115] "Now, children, I have learned from the writing of Enoch that at the end you will act ungodly against the Lord, laying hands on Him in every kind of wickedness, and your brothers will be ashamed because of you, and you will become a mockery to all the nations. [116] Our father Israel will be clean of the ungodliness of the high priests, who will lay their hands on the Savior of the world. [117] Heaven is purer than the earth, and you are the lights of heaven, like the sun and the moon. [118] What will all the nations

do if you are darkened in ungodliness and bring a curse on our race, you through whom the light of the world was given among you to enlighten every person? You will want to destroy Him, teaching commands opposed to the decrees of God. [119] You will rob the Lord's offerings, steal from His portions, and take the choice parts before sacrificing to the Lord, eating them with prostitutes in contempt. [120] In greed you will teach the Lord's commands, defile married women, pollute the virgins of Jerusalem, and join with prostitutes and adulteresses. You will take the daughters of the nations as wives, purifying them with an unlawful purification, and your union will become Sodom and Gomorrah in ungodliness. [121] You will be puffed up over the priesthood, lifting yourselves above people; and not only that, but also puffed up against the commands of God, [122] you will mock the holy things and laugh at them in contempt."

Chapter 15 (verses 123–126 here) [123] "For these reasons the temple the Lord chooses will be left empty in uncleanness, and you will be captives among all the nations, [124] and you will be an abomination among them, and receive reproach and everlasting shame from God's righteous judgment. [125] All who see you will flee from you. [126] If it were not for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob our fathers, not one of my seed would be left on the earth."

Chapter 16 (verses 127–131 here) [127] "Now I have learned in the book of Enoch that for seventy weeks you will go astray, defile the priesthood, and pollute the sacrifices, [128] destroy the law and despise the words of the prophets. In perversity you will persecute righteous men, hate the godly, and loathe the words of the truthful. [129] You will call a man who renews the law in the power of the Most High a deceiver, and in the end, as you think, you will kill him, not knowing his rising, taking innocent blood on your heads in wickedness. [130] Because of him your holy places will be desolate, defiled down to the ground, [131] and you will have no clean place, but among the nations you will be a curse and a scattering, until He visits again and, having mercy, receives you in faith and water."

Chapter 17 (verses 132–142 here) [132] "Since you have heard about the seventy weeks, now hear also about the priesthood. [133] In each jubilee

there will be a priesthood. In the first jubilee the first one anointed to the priesthood will be great, and he will speak to God as to a father. His priesthood will be filled with the fear of the Lord, and in the day of his joy he will rise for the salvation of the world. [134] In the second jubilee the anointed one will be seized in sorrow over those he loves, and his priesthood will be honored and he will be glorified by all. [135] The third priest will be taken in grief. [136] The fourth will be in pain, because injustice will be piled on him in abundance, and all Israel will hate one another. [137] The fifth will be taken in darkness. [138] So also the sixth and the seventh. [139] In the seventh there will be such defilement as I cannot describe, before the Lord and people. Those who do these things will know it. [140] Because of this they will be in captivity and plunder, and their land and their possessions will be destroyed. [141] In the fifth week they will return to their desolate land and renew the house of the Lord. [142] In the seventh week the priests will come, idolaters, quarrelsome, lovers of money, proud, lawless, shameless, corrupters of boys and abusers of animals."

Chapter 18 (verses 143–156 here) [143] "After the Lord's punishment of them has come on the priesthood, [144] then the Lord will raise up a new priest, to whom all the words of the Lord will be revealed. He will carry out true judgment on the earth for many days. [145] His star will rise in heaven like a king's, lighting the light of knowledge as the sun lights the day, and he will be magnified in the whole world until his taking up. [146] He will shine like the sun on the earth and remove all darkness from under heaven, and there will be peace in all the earth. [147] The heavens will rejoice in his days, the earth will be glad, the clouds will be joyful, and the knowledge of the Lord will be poured out on the earth like the water of the seas. The angels of the glory of the Lord's presence will rejoice in him. [148] The heavens will be opened, and from the temple of glory sanctification will come on him with a fatherly voice, as from Abraham to Isaac. [149] The glory of the Most High will be spoken over him, and the spirit of understanding and sanctification will rest on him in the water. [150] He will give the majesty of the Lord to his sons in truth forever, and he will have no successor, from generation to generation, forever. [151] In his priesthood

all sin will cease, the lawless will stop doing evil, and the righteous will find rest in him. [152] He will open the doors of Paradise and remove the threatening sword against Adam, [153] and give the holy ones to eat from the tree of life, and the spirit of holiness will be on them. [154] Beliar will be bound by him, and he will give his children authority to trample the evil spirits. [155] The Lord will rejoice over His children, and be pleased with His beloved ones forever. [156] Then Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob will be glad, and I will rejoice, and all the holy ones will put on gladness."

Chapter 19 (verses 157–161 here) [157] "Now, my children, you have heard everything. Choose for yourselves either darkness or light, either the law of the Lord or the works of Beliar." [158] We answered our father, "We will walk before the Lord, according to His law." [159] Our father said, "The Lord is witness, His angels are witnesses, I am a witness, and you are witnesses to the word of your mouth." And we said, "Witnesses." [160] So Levi finished commanding his sons, stretched out his feet, and was gathered to his fathers, having lived a hundred and thirty-seven years. [161] They laid him in a coffin, later they buried him in Hebron, beside Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

Notes

- a (3:1) "Levi" (Hebrew *Levi*) is explained in Gen 29:34 by a wordplay on "joined," as the wife hopes her husband will be "joined" to her. The name is also the root of "Levite."
- b (3:3) "Haran" (Hebrew *Charan*) is the northern Mesopotamian city where Jacob lived with Laban; the name probably means "road" or "caravan stop."
- c (3:4) "Hamor" (Hebrew *Chamor*) means "donkey." He was the ruler of Shechem in Gen 34.
- d (3:4) "Dinah" (Hebrew *Dinah*) means "judgment" or "justice." She is Jacob's daughter by Leah.
- e (3:5) "Abelmaul" is the Greek form of a place name; it is probably Abel-meholah or Abel-maim ("meadow of the waters"), in the north of the land.
- f (3:46) "Jebla" is the form of the name in the Greek copies; the person is otherwise unknown. Some copies read differently.
- g (3:52) "Bethel" (Hebrew *Beit-El*) means "house of God." It lies in the hill country north of Jerusalem.
- h (3:91) "Milcah" (Hebrew *Milkah*) means "queen." The Greek here has a different form of the name.

- i (3:92) "Gershom" (Hebrew *Gershom*) is explained in Exod 2:22 as "a sojourner there."
- j (3:94) "Kohath" (Hebrew *Qehat*) is of uncertain meaning; the text here explains it as "beginning of majesty and assembling."
- k (3:97) "Merari" (Hebrew *Merari*) is linked to the word for "bitter."
- l (3:98) "Jochebed" (Hebrew *Yokheved*) is probably "Yahweh is glory." She is the mother of Moses in Exod 6:20.

Chapter 4

The Testament of Judah, on Courage, Greed, and Sexual Immorality

Chapter 1 (verses 1–6 here) 1 A copy of the words of Judah,[a] all that
he said to his sons before he died. 2 They gathered and came to him,
and he said to them, 3 "I was the fourth son born to my father, and my
mother named me Judah, saying, 'I give thanks to the Lord, who has
given me a fourth son also.' 4 I was quick and eager in my youth, and
obedient to my father in everything. 5 I blessed my mother and my
mother's sister. 6 When I grew to manhood, my father Jacob prayed
over me, saying, 'You will be king and will prosper in everything.'"
Chapter 2 (verses 7–13 here) 7 "The Lord gave me favor in all my work,
in the field and at home. 8 When I saw that I had caught up with a
deer, I seized it and made a meal for my father. 9 I caught gazelles by
running, and overtook everything that lived in the plains. I overtook
a wild mare and tamed it. 10 I killed a lion and took a young goat from
its mouth. I took a bear by the foot and rolled it down a cliff, and any
animal that turned on me I tore apart like a dog. 11 I ran down the
wild boar, got ahead of it as I ran, and tore it to pieces. 12 A leopard
in Hebron leaped on the dog; I seized it by the tail and flung it, and
it burst apart in the territory of Gaza. 13 I grabbed a wild ox grazing
in the country by its horns, spun it around until it was dizzy, threw
it down, and killed it."
Chapter 3 (verses 14–23 here) 14 "When the two kings of the Canaanites
came in full armor against the flocks, with a large army, I ran out
alone at King Shur,[b] gripped him, struck him on the shins, pulled
him down, and killed him. 15 The other king, Taphue, was sitting on
his horse; I killed him too, and so scattered the whole army. 16 King

Achor, a man of giants, who shot arrows forward and backward from horseback, I lifted up; I hurled a sixty-pound stone[c] and struck his horse, and I killed him. 17 I fought Achor for two hours and killed him, and splitting his shield in two, I cut off his feet. 18 While I was stripping off his breastplate, eight of his companions began to attack me. 19 I wound my cloak around my hand, slung stones at them, and killed four of them; the rest fled. 20 Our father Jacob killed Beelesa, king of all the kings, a giant in strength, eighteen feet tall.[d] 21 Trembling fell on them, and they stopped fighting us. 22 That is why my father had no worry in the wars when I was with my brothers. 23 He had seen in a vision about me that an angel of power followed me in everything, so that I would not be defeated."

Chapter 4 (verses 24–26 here) 24 "To the south we had a war greater than the one at Shechem. I drew up in battle line with my brothers and chased a thousand men, and killed two hundred of them and four kings. 25 I went up against them on the wall and killed two more kings. 26 In this way we freed Hebron and took all the plunder of the kings."

Chapter 5 (verses 27–33 here) 27 "The next day we went to Areta, a strong city, walled and unapproachable, that threatened us with death. 28 Gad and I approached from the east side of the city; Reuben and Levi from the west and south. 29 The men on the wall, thinking we were alone, were drawn out against us. 30 So my brothers, secretly, from both sides, climbed the wall on pegs and entered the city while the people did not know. 31 We took it with the edge of the sword, and those who had fled to the tower we took by sawing the tower down with them in it. 32 As we were leaving, men from Taphu fell on our plunder, took it with our sons, and we engaged them as far as Taphu. 33 We killed them, burned the city, and plundered everything in it."

Chapter 6 (verses 34–38 here) 34 "While I was at the waters of Chuzeba, the men from Jobel came against us for war. 35 We engaged them and killed them and their allies from Shelom, and we gave them no way through to reach us. 36 On the fifth day men from Machir attacked us to take the plunder. We met them in a hard fight and overcame them, though they were a strong crowd, and we killed them before they could climb the slope. 37 When we came to their city, their women

rolled stones down on us from the top of the mountain where the city stood. 38 Simeon and I hid and came up behind them, took the high ground, and destroyed the whole city."

Chapter 7 (verses 39–49 here) 39 "The next day we were told that the cities of the two kings were coming against us with a great crowd. 40 So Dan and I, pretending to be Amorites, came into their city as allies. 41 In the deep of night we opened the gates to our brothers when they came, and destroyed them all and everything they had; we plundered all their goods and tore down their three walls. 42 We came near to Thamna,[e] where all the hostile kings had taken refuge. 43 Then, insulted, I was furious and charged at them toward the summit, while they slung stones and shot arrows at me. 44 If my brother Dan had not fought beside me, they would have killed me. 45 We came on them in a rage and they all fled. They went another way and begged my father, and he made peace with them, 46 and we did them no harm, but made them subjects under treaty, and gave back all the plunder. 47 I built Thamna and my father built Rambael. 48 I was twenty years old when this war happened, 49 and the Canaanites were afraid of me and my brothers."

Chapter 8 (verses 50–52 here) 50 "I also had many cattle, and had Hira the Adullamite[f] as my chief shepherd. 51 I went to him and saw Barsan, king of Adullam. He gave us a banquet, and in his friendliness he gave me his daughter Bathshua[g] as a wife. 52 She bore me Er, Onan, and Shelah.[h] The Lord killed the first two childless; Shelah lived, and you are his children."

Chapter 9 (verses 53–60 here) 53 "For eighteen years we were at peace, our father and we, with his brother Esau,[i] and his sons with us, after we had come from Mesopotamia, from Laban. 54 When eighteen years were complete, in the fortieth year of my life, Esau, my father's brother, came against us with a large and strong army. 55 Jacob's bow struck him down, and he was carried dead to Mount Seir; and as he was being carried up to Iramna, he died. 56 We pursued the sons of Esau. They had a city with an iron wall and bronze gates, and we could not enter it, so we sat down around it and besieged them. 57 When they did not open after twenty days, I set up a ladder in their

sight, with my shield over my head, and climbed up taking stones that weighed up to 225 pounds;[j] when I reached the top I killed four of their mighty men. [58] The next day Reuben and Gad went in and killed sixty others. [59] Then they asked us for terms of peace, and after consulting our father, we accepted them as tributaries. [60] They gave us 1,200 bushels[k] of wheat, 3,000 gallons[l] of oil, and 15,000 gallons[m] of wine, until we went down into Egypt.

Chapter 10 (verses 61–66 here) [61] "After this my son Er took Tamar,[n] the daughter of Aram, from Mesopotamia. [62] Er was wicked and was perplexed about Tamar, because she was not from the land of Canaan. An angel of the Lord killed him on the third night, [63] and he had not known her, through the scheming of his mother, for she did not want him to have children by her. [64] In the days of the wedding chamber I gave her to Onan as a husband; he too, in wickedness, did not know her, though he lived with her a year. [65] When I threatened him, he did go in to her, but he wasted the seed on the ground, following his mother's order; and he also died in his wickedness. [66] I wanted to give Shelah to her too, but my wife Bathshua would not allow it. She acted wickedly toward Tamar, because Tamar was not one of the daughters of Canaan, as she herself was."

Chapter 11 (verses 67–71 here) [67] "I knew that the race of Canaan was wicked, but the plans of youth blinded my heart. [68] When I saw her pouring wine, I was deceived by drunkenness and fell for her. [69] While I was away, she went and took a wife for Shelah from the land of Canaan. [70] When I learned what she had done, I cursed her in the anguish of my soul, [71] and she too died, through the wickedness of her sons."

Chapter 12 (verses 72–83 here) [72] "After these things, when Tamar had been a widow for two years, she heard that I was going up to shear the sheep, and she dressed herself in bridal clothes and sat opposite the city by the gate. [73] It was the law of the Amorites that a woman about to marry should sit in prostitution seven days by the gate. [74] I was drunk at the waters of Chozeba, and because of the wine I did not recognize her. Her beauty deceived me, through the manner of her dress. [75] I turned aside to her and said, 'Let me come in to you.'

She said, 'What will you give me?' I gave her my staff, my belt, and the diadem of my kingship, and when I went in to her she conceived. [76] Not knowing what she had done, I wanted to kill her; but she secretly sent the pledges, and she shamed me. [77] When I called her, I also heard the secret words I had spoken while sleeping with her in my drunkenness; and I could not kill her, because it was from the Lord. [78] I said, 'Perhaps she did it deceitfully, having taken the pledge from someone else.' [79] But I never went near her again until my death, because I had done an abomination in all Israel. [80] People in the city even said there was no temple prostitute in the city, because she had come from another place and sat only a short while at the gate, [81] and she thought that no one knew I had gone in to her. [82] After this we went to Egypt, to Joseph, because of the famine. [83] I was forty-six years old and lived seventy-three years there."

Chapter 13 (verses 84–91 here) [84] "Now listen, children, to your father about what I command you, and keep all my words, to do the decrees of the Lord and obey the command of the Lord God. [85] Do not follow your desires or the thoughts of your plans, in the pride of your heart, and do not boast in the deeds of your youthful strength, for this too is evil in the eyes of the Lord. [86] For I too boasted that in wars the face of a beautiful woman had never deceived me, and I used to reproach my brother Reuben about Bilhah, my father's wife. Then the spirit of jealousy and sexual immorality fought against me, until I fell for Bathshua the Canaanite and for Tamar, who was promised to my sons. [87] I said to my father-in-law, 'I will consult my father, and then I will take your daughter.' He showed me, in the name of his daughter, an unlimited amount of gold, for he was a king. [88] He dressed her in gold and pearls and made her pour wine for us at the dinner, in the beauty of women. [89] The wine twisted my eyes, and pleasure darkened my heart. [90] I fell in love with her, gave in, and broke the Lord's command and the command of my fathers, and I took her as my wife. [91] The Lord paid me back according to the plan of my heart, for I had no joy in her children."

Chapter 14 (verses 92–99 here) [92] "Now, my children, do not get drunk on wine, for wine twists the mind away from the truth, throws in the

anger of desire, and leads the eyes into error. [93] The spirit of sexual immorality has wine as its servant, to give pleasure to the mind; for these two together take away a person's strength. [94] If someone drinks wine to drunkenness, he disturbs his mind with filthy thoughts toward sexual immorality and heats his body toward intercourse; and if the occasion of desire is present, he commits the sin and is not ashamed. [95] Such is wine, my children: the drunk respects no one. [96] See, it led me astray too, so that I was not ashamed before the crowd in the city, for in the sight of all I turned aside to Tamar, and I committed a great sin, and uncovered the cover of my sons' shame. [97] After drinking wine I felt no shame before the command of God, and I took a Canaanite wife. [98] So a person who drinks wine needs understanding, my children, and this is the understanding about drinking: drink only as long as you keep your sense of shame. [99] If someone goes past this limit, wine invades the mind and produces the spirit of deceit. It makes the drunk speak shamefully and break the law without being ashamed, even boasting of his dishonor and thinking it good."

Chapter 15 (verses 100–104 here) [100] "One who commits sexual immorality and is stripped of his kingship does not get out of it; he is enslaved to immorality, as I was stripped. [101] For I gave away my staff, that is, the support of my tribe; and my belt, that is, my strength; and the diadem, that is, the glory of my kingdom. [102] After repenting of these things, I took neither wine nor meat until old age, and I saw no happiness. [103] The angel of God showed me that women rule over both king and poor man forever, [104] and take from the king his glory, from the brave man his strength, and from the poor man the little support of his poverty."

Chapter 16 (verses 105–108 here) [105] "So watch the limit with wine, my children. There are four evil spirits in it: of desire, of burning passion, of recklessness, of shameful gain. [106] If you drink wine in gladness, with respect and the fear of God, you will live. But if you drink without respect, and the fear of God is gone, then drunkenness follows and shamelessness creeps in. [107] If you do not drink at all, you will not sin in words of insult, quarreling, slander, and breaking the

commands of God, and you will not perish before your time. [108] Wine even reveals the mysteries of God and people to outsiders, as I too revealed the commands of God and the mysteries of my father Jacob to the Canaanite Bathshua, things God had said not to reveal. Wine is also the cause of war and disorder."

Chapter 17 (verses 109–114 here) [109] "I command you, my children, not to love money or look at the beauty of women, because it was for money and beauty that I was led astray to Bathshua the Canaanite. [110] I know that because of these two things, my descendants will be evil, [111] for they will change even the wise men among my sons and cause the kingdom of Judah to shrink, the kingdom the Lord gave me for obeying my father. [112] I never grieved the word of Jacob my father, for everything he said I did. [113] Abraham, my father's father, blessed me to be king in Israel, and Isaac likewise blessed me in the same way. [114] I know that the kingdom will be established from me."

Chapter 18 (verses 115–120 here) [115] "I have read in the books of Enoch the righteous what evils you will do in the last days. [116] So beware, my children, of sexual immorality and love of money; listen to Judah your father, [117] for these things pull people away from the law of God, blind the plans of the soul, teach pride, and do not let a person show mercy to his neighbor, [118] rob his soul of all goodness, hold him in toil and suffering, take his sleep away, and eat up his flesh, [119] hinder the sacrifices of God, forget blessings, do not listen to a prophet speaking, and are irritated by words of godliness. [120] For the person who serves two passions opposed to the commands of God cannot obey God, because they have blinded his soul, and he walks in the day as in the night."

Chapter 19 (verses 121–124 here) [121] "My children, love of money leads to idols, for those led astray by money name as gods those who are not gods, and it makes whoever has it fall into madness. [122] Because of money I lost my children, and if it had not been for the repentance of my flesh, the humbling of my soul, and the prayers of my father Jacob, I would have died childless. [123] But the God of my fathers, the compassionate and merciful, forgave me because I acted in ignorance. [124] The ruler of deceit had blinded me, and I was ignorant, as a human

being, as flesh corrupted by sins. I came to know my own weakness, though I had thought I was unbeatable."

Chapter 20 (verses 125–129 here) [125] "Know, then, my children, that two spirits are at work in a person, the spirit of truth and the spirit of deceit. [126] In the middle is the understanding of the mind, which inclines whichever way it wishes. [127] The things of truth and the things of deceit are written on the human chest, and the Lord knows each one of them. [128] There is no time when a person's deeds can escape notice, for they are written on the bones of his chest before the Lord. [129] The spirit of truth testifies to everything and accuses everyone, and the one who sinned is burned from within by his own heart, and cannot lift his face to the judge."

Chapter 21 (verses 130–138 here) [130] "Now, children, love Levi so that you may last, and do not exalt yourselves over him, or you will be destroyed. [131] The Lord gave the kingship to me and the priesthood to him, and put the kingship under the priesthood. [132] He gave me the things of earth and gave him the things in heaven. [133] As heaven is above earth, so the priesthood of God is above the kingdom on earth. [134] For the Lord chose him over you to draw near to Him, to eat at His table, and to receive the firstfruits, the delicacies of the sons of Israel. [135] You will be to them like the sea. In the sea the just and the unjust are tossed by storms, some taken captive and some growing rich; so in you every kind of person: some endangered, taken captive, and others enriched by plunder. [136] Those who rule will be like sea monsters, swallowing people like fish. They will enslave free sons and daughters, and seize houses, fields, flocks, and goods; [137] they will feed the flesh of many, unjustly, to ravens and ibises, and they will advance in evil, lifting themselves up in greed. [138] There will be false prophets like storms, and they will persecute all the righteous."

Chapter 22 (verses 139–141 here) [139] "The Lord will bring divisions against one another on them, and there will be constant wars in Israel, [140] and my kingdom will be brought to an end among foreigners, until the salvation of Israel comes, until the coming of the God of righteousness, so that Jacob and all the nations may rest in peace. [141] He will keep the strength of my kingdom forever. For the Lord swore

to me with an oath that my kingdom and my seed's would not fail all the days, forever."

Chapter 23 (verses 142–146 here) [142] "I am very grieved, my children, over the shamelessness, sorcery, and idolatry you will commit against the kingdom, following mediums, omen-readers, and demons of deceit. [143] You will make your daughters musicians and public women, and you will mingle in the abominations of the nations. [144] For this the Lord will bring on you famine and plague, death and avenging sword, siege, dogs to tear your enemies apart, reproaches from friends, ruin and the rotting of eyes, the killing of children, the taking of wives, the plundering of possessions, the burning of the temple of God, the desolation of the land, and your own slavery among the nations. [145] They will castrate some of you to serve their wives as eunuchs. [146] When you return to the Lord with humble heart, repenting and walking in all the commands of God, the Lord will visit you in mercy and in love, bringing you out of the captivity of your enemies."

Chapter 24 (verses 147–152 here) [147] "After this a star will rise for you from Jacob in peace, and a man will rise from my seed like the sun of righteousness, walking with the sons of men in gentleness and righteousness, and no sin will be found in him. [148] The heavens will be opened over him to pour out the blessing of the Holy Father's spirit, and he will pour out the spirit of grace on you, [149] and you will be his sons in truth, and you will walk in his commandment, first and last. [150] This is the branch of God Most High, and this is the spring for the life of all flesh. [151] Then the scepter of my kingdom will shine, and a stem will grow from your root. [152] From it will rise a rod of righteousness for the nations, to judge and save all who call on the Lord."

Chapter 25 (verses 153–157 here) [153] "After this Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob will rise to life, and I and my brothers will be chiefs, each with our scepter in Israel: Levi first, I second, Joseph third, Benjamin fourth, Simeon fifth, Issachar sixth, and so on in order, all of them. [154] The Lord blessed Levi; the angel of the presence, me; the powers of glory, Simeon; heaven, Reuben; the earth, Issachar; the sea, Zebulun; the mountains, Joseph; the tabernacle, Benjamin; the lights, Dan; delight, Naphtali; the sun, Gad; the olive tree, Asher. [155] There will be

one people of the Lord and one language, and the spirit of deceit of Beliar will be no more, for he will be thrown into the fire forever. [156] Those who died in sorrow will rise in joy; those who were poor for the Lord's sake will be made rich; those in need will be filled; those in weakness will be strong; and those who died for the Lord will be awakened to life. [157] The deer of Jacob will run in gladness, and the eagles of Israel will fly in joy. The ungodly will mourn, the sinners will weep, and all peoples will glorify the Lord forever."

Chapter 26 (verses 158–161 here) [158] "So keep every law of the Lord, my children, for there is hope for all who make his way straight." [159] He said to them, "I am a hundred and nineteen years old, and today I am dying before your eyes. [160] Let no one bury me in costly clothing or cut open my belly, because those who rule will do these things. And take me up to Hebron with you." [161] After saying this Judah fell asleep, and his sons did everything he had commanded and buried him in Hebron with his fathers.

Notes

- a (4:1) "Judah" (Hebrew *Yehudah*) is explained in Gen 29:35 as "I will praise Yahweh."
- b (4:14) "Shur" and the other royal names in these chapters (Taphue, Achor, Beelesa) are unknown outside this book. The spellings follow the Greek.
- c (4:16) The Greek says "sixty litrai," a litra being the Roman pound of about 12 ounces (327 g), so about 43 pounds (19.6 kg).
- d (4:20) The Greek says "twelve cubits"; at about 18 inches to the cubit this is about 18 feet (5.5 m).
- e (4:42) "Thamna" is the Greek spelling of Timnah, the town in the hill country of Judah, which means "allotted portion."
- f (4:50) "Hira" (Hebrew *Chirah*) is the Adullamite friend of Judah in Gen 38:1. "Adullam" was a town in the lowland of Judah.
- g (4:51) "Bathshua" (Hebrew *Bat-shua*) means "daughter of Shua" or "daughter of nobility." In Gen 38:2 she is the Canaanite mother of Judah's sons; the Greek spells the name "Bessous."
- h (4:52) "Er" (Hebrew *Er*) may mean "watchful"; "Onan" (Hebrew *Onan*) may mean "vigor"; "Shelah" (Hebrew *Shelah*) probably means "request" or "petition." The Greek spells the last one "Shelom."
- i (4:53) "Esau" (Hebrew *Esav*) is Jacob's twin brother, "hairy" or "made."
- j (4:57) The Greek says "up to three talents." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg), so three talents is about 225 pounds (about 100 kg).

- k (4:60) "Two hundred cors." A cor was about 6 bushels (about 220 liters), so about 1,200 bushels (44,000 liters). The size of the cor varied.
- l (4:60) "Five hundred baths." A bath was about 6 gallons (about 22 liters), so about 3,000 gallons (11,000 liters).
- m (4:60) "One thousand five hundred measures"; the Greek says only "measures" (*metra*), and the size is uncertain. If the measure was the metretes, about 10 gallons (39 liters), this would be about 15,000 gallons (59,000 liters)."
- n (4:61) "Tamar" (Hebrew *Tamar*) means "date palm."

Chapter 5

The Testament of Issachar, on Simplicity

Chapter 1 (verses 1–15 here) 1 A copy of the words of Issachar.[a] He called his sons and said to them, "Listen, children, to Issachar your father; give ear to the words of one beloved by the Lord. 2 I was born as the fifth son of Jacob, as the wages for mandrakes. 3 Jacob had brought mandrakes in from the field, and Rachel[b] met him and took them. 4 Reuben[c] was crying, and at the sound of him my mother Leah[d] came out. 5 These were sweet-smelling apples, which the land of Aram produced on high ground below a ravine of waters. 6 Rachel said, 'I will not give them to you, for they will take the place of children for me.' 7 There were two apples. Leah said, 'Let it be enough for you that you took the husband of my maidenhood. Will you take these too?' 8 Rachel said, 'See, let Jacob be yours tonight in exchange for your son's mandrakes.' 9 Leah said to her, 'Do not boast or glorify yourself. Jacob is mine, and I am the wife of his youth.' 10 Rachel said, 'What of it? He was betrothed to me first, and for my sake he served our father fourteen years. 11 What am I to do to you, since deceit and cunning have multiplied among people, and deceit advances on the earth? Otherwise you would not be looking on Jacob's face; 12 for you are not his wife, but were brought in by trickery in my place. 13 My father deceived me, and moved me aside that night and did not let me see; for if I had been there, this would not have happened.' 14 Then Rachel said, 'Take one mandrake, and in exchange for the one I will hire him out to you for one night.' 15 So Jacob knew Leah, and she conceived and bore me; and because of the wages I was called Issachar."

Chapter 2 (verses 16–20 here) [16] "Then an angel of the Lord appeared to Jacob and said that Rachel would bear two children, because she had spat on a husband's company and had chosen self-control. [17] If my mother Leah had not given up the two apples in exchange for company, she would have borne eight sons. That is why she bore six, and Rachel the two, because the Lord visited her over the mandrakes. [18] He saw that she wanted to be with Jacob for the sake of children and not for love of pleasure. [19] For the next day she gave Jacob up again, in order to get the other mandrake as well. That is why the Lord listened to Rachel over the mandrakes; [20] for although she longed for them, she did not eat them, but dedicated them in the house of the Lord, bringing them to the priest of the Most High who was there at that time."

Chapter 3 (verses 21–28 here) [21] "When I grew to manhood, my children, I walked in uprightness of heart, and became a farmer for my fathers and my brothers, and brought in produce from the fields in its season. [22] My father blessed me, seeing that I walked in simplicity. [23] I was not meddlesome in my actions, nor was I wicked or envious toward my neighbor. [24] I never spoke against anyone, nor criticized any person's way of life, but walked with simple eyes. [25] For this reason I took a wife only at thirty, because toil consumed my strength; I did not think about a woman's pleasure, but from the labor sleep overcame me, [26] and my father was always glad over my simplicity. Whenever I worked hard, I first brought every fruit and every first produce to the Lord through the priest, then to my father, and only then took some myself. [27] The Lord doubled the good things in my hands. Jacob also knew that God worked together with my simplicity, [28] for to every poor person and every afflicted person I gave of the good things of the land, in simplicity of heart."

Chapter 4 (verses 29–34 here) [29] "Now listen to me, children, and walk in simplicity of heart, for I have seen in it everything that pleases the Lord. [30] The simple person does not desire gold; he does not take advantage of his neighbor; he does not crave a variety of foods; he does not want expensive clothing; [31] he does not plan to live a long time, but only waits for the will of God. [32] The spirits of error have

no power against him. He does not even look at a woman's beauty, so that he will not pollute his mind with perversion. [33] Envy does not enter his thoughts; jealousy does not waste away his soul; and he does not scheme for gain out of insatiable greed. [34] He walks in uprightness of life and sees everything in simplicity, not letting his eyes take in wickedness from the world's error, so that he will not see any of the Lord's commands in a twisted way."

Chapter 5 (verses 35–42 here) [35] "So keep the law of God, my children, and acquire simplicity, and walk in innocence, not prying into the Lord's commands or into the neighbor's affairs, [36] but love the Lord and your neighbor, and show mercy to the poor and the sick. [37] Bend your backs to farming, and work at the tasks of the land in every kind of cultivation, bringing gifts to the Lord with thanksgiving; [38] for the Lord has blessed you with the first fruits of the earth, as he blessed all the holy ones from Abel until now. [39] No other portion has been given to you than that of the richness of the earth, whose fruits come with labor. [40] For our father Jacob blessed me with the blessings of the earth and of the first fruits. [41] Levi and Judah were glorified by the Lord among the sons of Jacob. For the Lord assigned them their lots, giving the priesthood to the one and the kingship to the other. [42] So obey them, and walk in the simplicity of your father; for to Gad it was given to destroy the raiding bands that attack Israel."

Chapter 6 (verses 43–46 here) [43] "I know, my children, that in the last times your sons will abandon simplicity and cling to greed; leaving innocence, they will approach wickedness; abandoning the commands of the Lord, they will cling to Beliar;[e] [44] leaving farming, they will follow their own wicked plans. They will be scattered among the nations and will serve their enemies. [45] So tell these things to your children, so that if they sin, they will turn back to the Lord the sooner; [46] for he is merciful and will rescue them, to bring them back to their land."

Chapter 7 (verses 47–55 here) [47] "I am a hundred and twenty-two years old, and I have not known any sin that deserves death. [48] Apart from my wife, I have known no other woman. I never committed sexual immorality by lifting my eyes. [49] I never drank wine to be led astray.

I never longed for anything my neighbor desired. [50] There was no deceit in my heart. No lie went up through my lips. [51] I groaned with every person in pain, and shared my bread with the poor. I never ate alone. I never moved a boundary. I practiced godliness and truth all my days. [52] I loved the Lord with all my strength; and I loved every person as I did my own children. [53] Do these things too, my children, and every spirit of Beliar will flee from you, and no action of wicked people will rule over you. You will bring every wild beast under your power, having with you the God of heaven, who walks with people in simplicity of heart." [54] He commanded them to carry him up to Hebron and bury him there in the cave with his fathers. [55] Then he stretched out his feet and died, the fifth son, in a good old age, with every limb sound and strength intact, and he slept the sleep of eternity.

Notes

- a (5:1) "Issachar" (Hebrew *Yissakhar*) is explained in Gen 30:18 as "hire" or "reward," from the bargain over the mandrakes told in the next verses.
- b (5:3) "Rachel" (Hebrew *Rakhel*) means "ewe."
- c (5:4) "Reuben" (Hebrew *Re'uven*) is explained in Gen 29:32 as "See, a son!"
- d (5:4) "Leah" (Hebrew *Le'ah*) may mean "wild cow" or "weary."
- e (5:43) "Beliar" is a name for the chief evil spirit, from Hebrew *Beliyya'al*, "worthlessness."

Chapter 6

The Testament of Zebulun, on Compassion and Mercy

Chapter 1 (verses 1–7 here) [1] A copy of the words of Zebulun,[a] which he laid down for his children in the hundred and fourteenth year of his life, thirty-two years after the death of Joseph. [2] He said to them, "Listen to me, sons of Zebulun; pay attention to the words of your father. [3] I am Zebulun, a good gift to my parents. When I was born our father grew very rich, in flocks and herds, when he took his share by means of the striped rods. [4] I do not know, my children, that I have sinned in my days, except in thought. [5] Nor do I remember doing any lawless act, except the ignorance I showed over Joseph, for I covered up for my brothers and did not tell my father what had happened. [6] I wept a great deal in secret, for I was afraid of my brothers, because they had all agreed together that if anyone revealed the secret, he

would be killed with the sword. 7 When they wanted to kill Joseph, I pleaded with them at length, in tears, not to commit this lawless act."
Chapter 2 (verses 8–16 here) 8 "Simeon and Gad came at Joseph to kill him. Falling on his face, Joseph said to them, 9 'Have pity on me, my brothers; have mercy on the heart of Jacob our father. Do not lay your hands on me to shed innocent blood, for I have not sinned against you. 10 And if I have sinned, punish me with discipline, but do not lay your hand on me, for the sake of Jacob our father.' 11 As he spoke these words, I was moved to pity and began to weep; my liver dissolved within me, and the whole substance of my insides melted into my soul. 12 Joseph wept, and I with him; my heart pounded, and the joints of my body gave way, so that I could not stand. 13 When he saw me weeping with him, and the others coming to kill him, he took refuge behind me, begging them. 14 Reuben stood up and said, 'Brothers, let us not kill him, but throw him into one of these dry pits, which our fathers dug and found no water.' 15 For this reason the Lord had kept water from rising in them, so that Joseph would be preserved. 16 The Lord did this until they sold him to the Ishmaelites."
Chapter 3 (verses 17–24 here) 17 "I had no share in the price of Joseph, children, 18 but Simeon and Gad and our other six brothers took the price of Joseph and bought sandals for themselves, their wives, and their children, saying, 19 'We will not eat it, since it is the price of our brother's blood, but we will trample it, because he said he would be king over us. Let us see what becomes of his dreams.' 20 For this reason it is written in the writing of the law of Enoch[b] that whoever does not want to raise up seed for his brother is to have his sandal taken off and be spat on in the face. 21 Joseph's brothers did not want their brother to live, and the Lord took the sandal off them in Joseph's case. 22 For when they came to Egypt, Joseph's servants took their sandals off in front of the gate, and so they bowed down to Joseph in the manner of Pharaoh's court. 23 They not only bowed to him but were spat on, falling down right away in front of him, and so they were shamed in front of the Egyptians. 24 After this the Egyptians heard about all the evil we had done to Joseph."

Chapter 4 (verses 25–37 here) [25] "After this, they sat down to eat. [26] I tasted nothing for two days and two nights, in pity for Joseph. Judah did not eat with them but kept watch at the pit, for he was afraid Simeon and Gad would jump up and kill him. [27] When they saw me too not eating, they appointed me to guard him until he was sold. [28] He spent three days and three nights in the pit, and so he was sold without having eaten. [29] When Reuben heard that Joseph had been sold in his absence, he tore his clothes and mourned, saying, 'How can I look on the face of Jacob my father?' [30] He took the money and ran after the merchants, but found no one; they had left the main road and gone by a shortcut through cave-ridden country. [31] Reuben ate no bread that day. Dan came to him and said, [32] 'Do not cry and do not mourn, for I have found what we can tell our father Jacob. [33] Let us slaughter a kid of the goats and dip Joseph's tunic in its blood, and say, "See whether this is your son's tunic."' [34] They had stripped off the tunic of our father that Joseph was wearing when he was about to be sold, and dressed him in a slave's old cloak. [35] Simeon had the tunic and did not want to give it up, wishing to hack it with his sword, angry that Joseph lived and he had not killed him. [36] All of us together stood up against him and said that if he did not hand it over, we would say that he alone had done this evil in Israel. [37] So he gave it over, and they did as Dan had said."

Chapter 5 (verses 38–42 here) [38] "Now, my children, I will tell you to keep the commands of the Lord, to show mercy toward your neighbor, and to have compassion toward everyone, not only toward people, but also toward animals. [39] For because of these things the Lord blessed me, and when all my brothers were sick, I passed through without illness; for the Lord knows each one's purpose. [40] So have mercy in your hearts, my children, because as someone treats his neighbor, so the Lord will treat him. [41] The sons of my brothers were sick and were dying because of Joseph, since they showed no mercy in their hearts; but my sons were kept healthy, as you know. [42] When I was in Canaan, at the seacoast, I used to catch fish for Jacob my father; and while many were drowning in the sea, I remained unharmed."

Chapter 6 (verses 43–50 here) [43] "I was the first to make a boat to sail on the sea, because the Lord gave me understanding and wisdom for it. [44] I set a rudder at the back, and spread a sail on an upright pole in the middle. [45] Sailing in it along the shores, I fished for the house of my father until we came to Egypt. [46] From my catch I gave to every stranger out of compassion. [47] If someone was a stranger, or sick, or old, I would boil the fish, prepare them well, and offer them to all according to each one's need, sharing their pain along with them. [48] For this reason the Lord also gave me plenty of fish to catch; whoever gives to his neighbor receives many times more from the Lord. [49] I fished for five years, giving to everyone I saw and providing enough for the whole house of my father. [50] In summer I fished; in winter I shepherded with my brothers."

Chapter 7 (verses 51–54 here) [51] "Now I will tell you what I did. I saw a man in distress, naked in the winter cold. In pity for him, I secretly took a cloak from my own house and gave it to the man in distress. [52] You too, my children, from what God provides you, show mercy to all without distinction, and give to everyone with a good heart. [53] If you do not have anything to give to the needy at that time, share their pain with a heart of mercy. [54] I know that my hand did not find anything to give to someone in need at the moment, and still I walked with him nearly a mile[c] and wept; my heart turned inside me in sympathy for him."

Chapter 8 (verses 55–60 here) [55] "So you too, my children, have compassion in mercy for every person, so that the Lord will also have compassion and mercy on you; [56] for in the last days God will send his compassion on the earth, and wherever he finds hearts of mercy, he will live in them. [57] To the degree that a person has compassion on his neighbor, the Lord will have that much on him. [58] When we went down to Egypt, Joseph did not hold a grudge against us; and when he saw me, he was moved with compassion. [59] Looking to him, you too, my children, be free of grudges, and love one another, and do not keep count of each other's wrongs; [60] for this breaks up unity, scatters every family, and troubles the soul. A person who holds a grudge has no heart of mercy."

Chapter 9 (verses 61–69 here) [61] "Look at the water: it goes in one direction, sweeping along stones, sticks, and sand. [62] If it is divided into many streams, the earth swallows them up, and they become worth nothing. [63] You too will be like this if you are divided. [64] Do not be split into two heads, for everything the Lord made has one head. He gave two shoulders, hands, and feet, but all the limbs obey the one head. [65] I learned in the writing of my fathers that in the last days you will fall away from the Lord and be divided in Israel; you will follow two kings, commit every abomination, and worship every idol; [66] your enemies will take you captive, and you will live among the nations in all kinds of weakness, affliction, and pain of soul. [67] After that you will remember the Lord and repent, and he will bring you back, because he is merciful and compassionate and does not hold evil against human beings, since they are flesh and the spirits of error deceive them in everything they do. [68] After that the Lord himself will rise on you, the light of righteousness, with healing and compassion in his wings. He will redeem every captive of the sons of men from Beliar, and every spirit of error will be trampled. He will turn all the nations to jealousy for him, and you will see God in the form of a man, whom the Lord will choose, whose name is Jerusalem. [69] And again, by the wickedness of your words, you will provoke him to anger, and you will be rejected until the time of the end."

Chapter 10 (verses 70–76 here) [70] "Now, my children, do not grieve that I am dying, or be cast down because I am leaving you. [71] I will rise again among you as a leader among his sons, and I will rejoice among my tribe, with all who kept the law of the Lord and the commands of Zebulun their father. [72] But on the ungodly the Lord will bring eternal fire, and he will destroy them through the generations. [73] I am running to my rest, as my fathers did. [74] You, fear the Lord your God with all your strength all the days of your life." [75] After he said this, he fell asleep in a good sleep, and his sons laid him in a coffin. [76] Later they carried him up to Hebron and buried him with his fathers.

Notes

- a (6:1) "Zebulun" (Hebrew *Zevulun*) is explained in Gen 30:20 as "honor" or "dwelling."

- b (6:20) "Enoch" (Hebrew *Chanokh*) means "dedicated" or "initiated." The "law of Enoch" is not found in the Hebrew Bible; the rule resembles Deut 25:5–10, and the reference may be to the books of Enoch.
- c (6:54) "Seven stadia." A stadion was about 607 feet (185 m), so seven stadia is about 0.8 mile (1.3 km).

Chapter 7

The Testament of Dan, on Anger and Lying

Chapter 1 (verses 1–9 here) 1 A copy of the words of Dan,[a] which
he spoke to his sons in the last days of his life, in the hundred and
twenty-fifth year of his life. 2 He called his clan together and said,
"Listen, sons of Dan, to my words; pay attention to the speech of
your father's mouth. 3 I have tested in my heart and through my
whole life that truth with right dealing is good and pleasing to God,
and that lying and anger are evil, because they teach a person every
wickedness. 4 I confess to you today, my children, that in my heart I
was pleased about the death of Joseph, a true and good man, 5 and I
rejoiced at the sale of Joseph, because his father loved him more than
us. 6 For the spirit of jealousy and arrogance said to me, 'You too are
his son.' 7 One of the spirits of Beliar worked with me, saying, 'Take
this sword, and with it kill Joseph; when he is dead, your father will
love you.' 8 This was the spirit of anger that persuaded me to suck
Joseph dry, as a leopard sucks dry a kid. 9 But the God of Jacob our
father did not hand him over into my hands so that I could find him
alone, nor did he let me carry out this lawless deed, which would
have broken the two scepters in Israel."

Chapter 2 (verses 10–14 here) 10 "Now, my children, I am dying, and I
tell you in truth that unless you guard yourselves against the spirit
of lying and of anger, and love truth and patience, you will perish. 11
There is blindness in anger, my children, and no angry person sees
a face truly. 12 Whether it is a father or a mother, he treats them as
enemies; if a brother, he does not know him; if a prophet of the Lord,
he disobeys; if a righteous man, he does not see him; a friend he does
not recognize. 13 For the spirit of anger wraps him in the nets of error,
blinds his natural eyes, darkens his mind with lying, and gives him
a vision of his own. 14 How does it wrap his eyes? With hatred in the

heart, and it gives him a heart of his own against his brother, out of envy."

Chapter 3 (verses 15–20 here) [15] "Anger is evil, my children, for it becomes a soul to the soul itself. [16] It takes the angry person's body as its own and rules his soul, giving his body power of its own to do every lawless act; [17] and when the soul does it, anger justifies what was done, because he does not see. [18] So the person who is angry, if he is powerful, has a threefold strength in his anger: one through his power and the help of those who serve him; the second through wealth, persuading and winning by injustice; the third the natural strength of his body, doing the evil himself. [19] If the angry person is weak, he has double the strength his nature gives, for anger always helps such people in lawless acts. [20] This spirit always walks with lying at the right hand of Satan, so that his deeds are done in cruelty and falsehood."

Chapter 4 (verses 21–27 here) [21] "So understand the power of anger, that it is empty. [22] First it provokes with a word; then through deeds it gives strength to the one who is stirred up, and with bitter losses it disturbs his judgment; and so it rouses his soul in great anger. [23] So when someone speaks against you, do not be moved to anger; and if anyone praises you as good, do not be puffed up or changed, either toward pleasure or toward appearance. [24] For first it delights the ear, and so it sharpens the mind to grasp what has been stirred up; and then, angry, one thinks he is rightly furious. [25] If you fall into a loss or the destruction of something, my children, do not be troubled; for this same spirit makes you long for what was lost, so that you become angry through the longing. [26] If you suffer loss willingly, do not be sad, for out of sadness it raises anger together with lying. [27] Anger and lying are a two-faced evil, and they join together to throw the mind into confusion. When the soul is continually troubled, the Lord withdraws from it, and Beliar rules it."

Chapter 5 (verses 28–40 here) [28] "So keep the Lord's commands, my children, and guard his law; keep away from anger and hate lying, so that the Lord may live in you and Beliar may flee from you. [29] Speak truth, each one to his neighbor, and you will not fall into pleasure

and disorder, but will be in peace, having the God of peace, and war will not overpower you. [30] Love the Lord all your life, and one another with a true heart. [31] For I know that in the last days you will depart from the Lord and become offended at Levi and set yourselves against Judah; but you will not be able to prevail against them. An angel of the Lord leads each, because Israel will stand through them. [32] When you depart from the Lord, you will walk in every evil, committing the abominations of the nations, going off with the wives of lawless people, while the spirits of error work in you in every wickedness. [33] I read in the book of Enoch the righteous that your ruler is Satan, and that all the spirits of sexual immorality and pride will obey Levi, in order to sit constantly beside the sons of Levi and make them sin before the Lord. [34] My sons will come near to Levi and sin together with them in everything; and the sons of Judah will be greedy, seizing what belongs to others like lions. [35] For this reason you will be led away with them into captivity, and there you will receive all the plagues of Egypt and all the evils of the nations; [36] and so when you return to the Lord you will receive mercy, and he will bring you into his sanctuary, calling out peace to you. [37] Out of the tribe of Judah and Levi the salvation of the Lord will rise for you; he himself will make war on Beliar, and will give the vengeance of victory to those at our borders. [38] He will take the captives from Beliar, the souls of the holy ones, and will turn disobedient hearts to the Lord, and will give everlasting peace to those who call on him, [39] and the holy ones will rest in Eden, and the righteous will rejoice in the new Jerusalem, which will be to the glory of God forever. [40] Jerusalem will no longer endure desolation, nor will Israel be taken captive, because the Lord will be in the middle of it, living with people, and the Holy One of Israel will reign over them in humility and poverty; and whoever believes in him will reign in truth in the heavens."

Chapter 6 (verses 41–51 here) [41] "Now fear the Lord, my children, and watch yourselves against Satan and his spirits. [42] Draw near to God and to the angel who intercedes for you, for he is a mediator between God and humanity for the peace of Israel. He will stand against the kingdom of the enemy. [43] For this reason the enemy is eager to trip up

all who call on the Lord. 44 He knows that on the day Israel believes, the kingdom of the enemy will be brought to an end. 45 The angel of peace himself will strengthen Israel, so that it does not fall into the final evil. 46 In the time of Israel's lawlessness the Lord will withdraw from them, and will go after those who do his will, because among the angels there will be none like him. 47 His name will be Savior in every place in Israel and among the nations. 48 So keep yourselves, my children, from every evil deed; throw away anger and all lying, and love truth and patience, 49 and pass on to your children what you heard from your father, so that the Father of the nations may receive you; for he is true and patient, gentle and humble, and teaches the law of God by his works. 50 So keep away from all injustice and cling to the righteousness of the law of the Lord. 51 And bury me near my fathers."

Chapter 7 (verses 52–54 here) 52 After saying this, he kissed them and fell asleep with the sleep of eternity. 53 His sons buried him, and afterward carried his bones up near Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. 54 But as Dan prophesied to them, that they would forget the law of their God and be alienated from the land of their inheritance and from the race of Israel and their family, so it happened.

Notes

- a (7:1) "Dan" (Hebrew *Dan*) means "he judged," as in Gen 30:6, "God has judged me."

Chapter 8

The Testament of Naphtali, on Natural Order

Chapter 1 (verses 1–12 here) 1 A copy of the testament of Naphtali,[a] which he laid down at the time of his end, in the hundred and thirty-second year of his life. 2 When his sons had gathered in the seventh month (September–October)[b] on the fourth day of the month, while he was in good health, he gave a dinner and a drinking party. 3 After he woke up the next morning, he told them he was dying; but they did not believe him. 4 Blessing the Lord, he insisted that he would die after the dinner of the day before. 5 Then he began to say to his sons, "Listen, my children, sons of Naphtali; listen to the words of

your father. [6] I was born of Bilhah.[c] Because Rachel acted shrewdly and gave Bilhah to Jacob in her place, and Bilhah bore me on Rachel's thighs, I was called Naphtali. [7] Rachel loved me because I was born on her thighs; and when I was a tender little thing she would kiss me, saying, 'May I see a brother of yours from my own womb, like you.' [8] So Joseph was like me in everything, following Rachel's prayers. [9] My mother Bilhah was the daughter of Rotheus, brother of Deborah, Rebekah's nurse, who was born on the same day as Rachel. [10] Rotheus was of the family of Abraham, a Chaldean, God-fearing, free and noble. [11] He was taken captive and bought by Laban, who gave him his slave woman Aina as a wife; she bore a daughter, and he called her Zilpah, after the name of the village where he had been taken captive. [12] After that she bore Bilhah, and he said, 'My daughter is eager for something new, for as soon as she was born she was in a hurry to nurse.'"

Chapter 2 (verses 13–22 here) [13] "Because I was light on my feet like a deer, my father Jacob assigned me to every errand and message; and he even blessed me as a deer. [14] As the potter knows a vessel, how much it holds, and brings clay accordingly, so the Lord makes the body to match the spirit, and fits the spirit to the power of the body. [15] Nothing is left over, not a third of a hair's breadth from one to another; for all creation of the Most High is by weight, measure, and rule. [16] As the potter knows the use of each vessel and what it suits, so the Lord knows the body: how far it will last in good, and when it begins in evil. [17] There is no creature and no thought that the Lord does not know, for he made every person in his own image. [18] As his strength is, so is his work; as his mind, so his work; as his choice, so his action; as his heart, so his mouth; as his eye, so his sleep; as his soul, so his word, either in the law of the Lord or in the law of Beliar. [19] Just as there is a separation between light and darkness, sight and hearing, so there is a separation between man and man, and between woman and woman; and one cannot say that one is the same as another in face or likeness. [20] God made everything good in order: he put the five senses in the head, joined the neck to the head, and hair for glory; then the heart for understanding, the belly for

sorting what the stomach takes in, the windpipe for health, the liver for anger, the gall for bitterness, the spleen for laughter, the kidneys for cunning, the loin muscles for power, the ribs as a case, the hip for strength, and so on. 21 So, my children, be in order for good things in the fear of God, and do nothing disorderly in contempt, or out of its proper time. 22 If you tell the eye to hear, it cannot; so you will not be able to do the works of light while in darkness."

Chapter 3 (verses 23–27 here) 23 "So do not hurry, in greed, to corrupt your actions, or to deceive your souls with empty words; for if you are silent with a pure heart, you will be able to hold to the will of God and throw off the will of the devil. 24 The sun, the moon, and the stars do not change their order; so you, do not change the law of God by disorder in your actions. 25 The nations went astray and left the Lord; they changed their order and followed stones and sticks, following spirits of error. 26 You must not be like that, my children, you who know in the sky, on earth, and in the sea, and in all that is made, the Lord who made all of it, so that you do not become like Sodom, which changed the order of its nature. 27 In the same way the Watchers changed the order of their nature, whom the Lord also cursed at the flood, and because of them he made the earth uninhabited and fruitless."

Chapter 4 (verses 28–32 here) 28 "I say this, my children, because I read in the holy writing of Enoch[d] that you too will depart from the Lord, going after every evil of the nations, and will commit every lawless act of Sodom. 29 The Lord will bring captivity on you, and there you will serve your enemies, and be covered with every ill-treatment and affliction, until the Lord has used up all of you. 30 After you have become few and small, you will return and know the Lord your God; and he will bring you back into your land, in his great mercy. 31 It will happen that when they arrive in the land of their fathers, they will again forget the Lord and become ungodly, 32 and the Lord will scatter them over the face of all the earth, until the compassion of the Lord comes, a man doing righteousness and showing mercy to all, far and near."

Chapter 5 (verses 33–40 here) [33] "In the fortieth year of my life, I saw on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem, that the sun and the moon stood still. [34] There was Isaac, my father's father, saying to us, 'Run and grab hold, each as you are able; whoever catches them will have the sun and the moon.' [35] We all ran together; Levi seized the sun, and Judah got there first and caught the moon, and both of them were lifted up with them. [36] When Levi was like the sun, a young man gave him twelve palm branches; and Judah was bright like the moon, and under his feet were twelve rays. [37] Levi and Judah ran to each other and held each other. [38] Then there was a bull on the earth, with two great horns and an eagle's wings on its back; we wanted to catch it, but could not. [39] Joseph got there first, caught it, and went up with it on high. [40] I saw that I was there somewhere, and a holy writing appeared to us, saying: 'Assyrians, Medes, Persians, Elymeans, Gelachaeans, Chaldeans, and Syrians will inherit, in captivity, the twelve tribes of Israel.'"

Chapter 6 (verses 41–50 here) [41] "Seven months later I saw our father Jacob standing by the sea of Jamnia, and we his sons were with him. [42] A ship came sailing, full of dried fish, without sailors or pilot; and on the ship was written 'Jacob.' [43] Our father said to us, 'Let us get on our ship.' [44] When we went in, a violent storm came, a whirlwind of great wind, and our father, who had been holding our necks, was torn away from us. [45] We were tossed in the storm and carried out to sea; the ship filled with water, battered by huge waves, until it began to break up. [46] Joseph fled on a small boat; we were separated too, onto ten planks; Levi and Judah were on the same one. [47] So we were all scattered, to the ends of the earth. [48] Levi, wrapped in sackcloth, prayed to the Lord for all of us. [49] When the storm stopped, the vessel reached land, as if in peace. [50] Then our father Jacob came, and we rejoiced together."

Chapter 7 (verses 51–54 here) [51] "I told these two dreams to my father, and he said to me, 'These must be fulfilled in their time, after Israel endures many things.' [52] Then my father said to me, 'I believe that Joseph is alive; for I always see that the Lord is counting him with you.' [53] Weeping, he said, 'You are alive, Joseph my child, and I do not

see you, and you do not see Jacob who fathered you.' [54] He made us weep, too, with these words. I burned inside to tell him that Joseph had been sold, but I was afraid of my brothers."

Chapter 8 (verses 55–64 here) [55] "Now, my children, I have shown you the last times, how all will happen in Israel. [56] So command your children to unite themselves to Levi and Judah. For through Judah salvation will rise for Israel, and in him Jacob will be blessed. [57] Through his scepter God will appear, living among people on the earth, to save the race of Israel; and he will gather the righteous from the nations. [58] If you do what is good, my children, people and angels will bless you; God will be glorified through you among the nations, the devil will flee from you, wild animals will fear you, and angels will hold on to you. [59] Just as someone who raises a child well has a good memory of it, so for a good deed there is a good memory with God. [60] But anyone who does not do good, people and angels will curse; God will be dishonored through him among the nations; the devil will claim him as his own tool; every wild animal will master him; and the Lord will hate him. [61] The commands of the law are twofold, and they are fulfilled with skill. [62] There is a time for a man's intercourse with his wife, and a time of self-control for his prayer. [63] These are two commands, and if they do not happen in their proper order, they bring sin. It is the same with the other commands. [64] So be wise in God and prudent, knowing the order of his commands and the rules for every matter, so that the Lord will love you."

Chapter 9 (verses 65–67 here) [65] After giving them many such commands, he asked them to carry his bones to Hebron and bury him with his fathers. [66] Then, after eating and drinking with a cheerful heart, he covered his face and died. [67] His sons did everything that their father Naphtali had commanded them.

Notes

- a (8:1) "Naphtali" (Hebrew *Naftali*) is explained in Gen 30:8 as "my wrestling," from Rachel's saying "I have wrestled with my sister."
- b (8:2) The Greek says "the seventh month, the fourth day of the month." Counted from spring, the seventh month of the Hebrew calendar (Tishri) falls in September–October, so the fourth day is early in that span.

- c (8:6) "Bilhah" (Hebrew *Bilhah*) is the maid of Rachel; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- d (8:28) "Enoch" is the patriarch whose books (the Books of Enoch) circulated in this period. The "holy writing of Enoch" is probably 1 Enoch, though the exact passage is not found there.

Chapter 9

The Testament of Gad, on Hatred

Chapter 1 (verses 1–9 here) 1 A copy of the testament of Gad,[a] which he spoke to his sons in the hundred and twenty-seventh year of his life, saying, 2 "I was the seventh son born to Jacob, and I was brave with the flocks. 3 I kept watch over the flock at night, and when a lion, a wolf, a leopard, a bear, or any wild animal came against the flock, I chased it down, caught its foot in my hand, spun it around until it was dizzy, and hurled it about a quarter of a mile,[b] and so killed it. 4 Joseph was shepherding with us for about thirty days, and, being delicate, he fell ill from the heat, 5 and went back to Hebron to his father, who made him lie down near him, because he loved him. 6 Joseph told our father that the sons of Zilpah and Bilhah were slaughtering the best animals and eating them, against the judgment of Judah and Reuben. 7 For he had seen that I snatched a lamb out of the bear's mouth, and killed the bear, and slaughtered the lamb, which I felt sorry about because it could not live, and we ate it; and he told our father. 8 I held a grudge against Joseph over this matter until the day he was sold into Egypt. 9 The spirit of hatred was in me, and I did not want to see Joseph with my eyes or hear him with my ears. He had reproved us to our faces because we were eating the animals without Judah; and everything he said to his father, his father believed."

Chapter 2 (verses 10–14 here) 10 "I confess my sin now, children: many times I wanted to kill him, because I hated him to the depth of my soul, and I had no mercy in my insides for him at all. 11 I even added to my hatred because of the dreams, and I wanted to lick him out of the land of the living, as a calf licks the green grass off the ground. 12 So Judah and I sold him to the Ishmaelites for thirty gold pieces; we hid ten of them and showed the twenty to our brothers. 13 In this way I was filled with greed for his removal. 14 But the God of my fathers

rescued him from my hands, so that I would not commit a lawless act in Israel."

Chapter 3 (verses 15–17 here) [15] "Now hear, my children, words of truth, to do righteousness and every law of the Most High, and not to be led astray by the spirit of hatred, because it is evil in all human actions. [16] Whatever the one who hates does, he finds disgusting. If someone keeps the law of the Lord, he does not praise it; if someone fears the Lord and wants what is just, he does not love him; [17] he blames the truth, envies the one who succeeds, welcomes slander, loves arrogance; for hatred has blinded his soul, as I too saw it in the case of Joseph."

Chapter 4 (verses 18–24 here) [18] "So guard yourselves, my children, against hatred, because it commits lawlessness against the Lord himself. [19] It refuses to hear the words of his commandments about love of neighbor, and it sins against God. [20] If a brother stumbles, it immediately wants to tell everyone and is eager to have him judged for it and punished until he dies. [21] If he is a slave, it sets him against his master, and in every affliction it attacks him, to see if it can put him to death. [22] Hatred works with envy, and it is always sick when it hears of or sees the progress of those who are doing well. [23] Just as love wants to give life even to the dead, and would call back those under a sentence of death, so hatred wants to kill the living, and does not want those who have sinned in some small thing to live. [24] The spirit of hatred, through faintheartedness, works with Satan in everything toward the death of human beings; the spirit of love, through patience, works with the law of God toward the salvation of human beings."

Chapter 5 (verses 25–35 here) [25] "Hatred is evil, for it continually dwells with lying, speaking against the truth. It makes small things large, treats darkness as light, calls sweet things bitter, and teaches slander, war, insult, and every abundance of evil, and it fills the heart with devilish poison. [26] I tell you these things from experience, my children, so that you will flee hatred and cling to the love of the Lord. [27] Righteousness drives out hatred, and humility destroys hatred. The righteous and humble person is ashamed to do what is unjust, not

because someone else condemns him but because his own heart does, for the Lord looks into his thoughts. [28] He does not speak against a man, since the fear of the Most High overcomes hatred. [29] For, afraid of offending the Lord, he does not want to wrong a person at all, not even in his thoughts. [30] I learned these things last, after I repented over Joseph. [31] True repentance before God removes disobedience, drives out darkness, lights up the eyes, gives knowledge to the soul, and guides the mind toward salvation, [32] and what he did not learn from human beings, he knows through repentance. [33] God brought a disease of the liver on me, and if it had not been for the prayers of Jacob my father, my spirit would very nearly have left me. [34] For a person is punished through the very things by which he breaks the law. [35] Since my liver had pressed mercilessly against Joseph, I suffered mercilessly in my liver, and was under judgment for eleven months, as long as I had held a grudge against Joseph, until he was sold."

Chapter 6 (verses 36–42 here) [36] "Now, my children, each of you love your brother, and remove hatred from your hearts, loving one another in deed, in word, and in the thinking of the soul. [37] In front of our father I spoke peaceably to Joseph, but when I left, the spirit of hatred darkened my mind and troubled my soul to kill him. [38] So love one another from the heart; and if someone sins against you, tell him so in peace, driving out the poison of hatred, and keep no deceit in your soul. If he confesses and repents, forgive him; [39] and if he denies it, do not argue with him, in case he swears and you sin twice. [40] Do not let an outsider hear your secret in a quarrel, so that he does not come to hate you and become your enemy and commit a great sin against you; for often he speaks deceitfully, or schemes against you for evil, having taken poison from you. [41] If he denies it, but is ashamed when he is reproved, let it rest; do not drag him out. The one who denies it is repenting, so that he will not offend you again; he will even honor you, fear you, and be at peace with you. [42] But if he is shameless and persists in evil, even so forgive him from your heart, and give vengeance to God."

Chapter 7 (verses 43–49 here) [43] "If anyone prospers more than you, do not be sad; rather pray for him, that he may prosper completely.

Perhaps it is good for you this way. [44] If he is lifted up still more, do not envy him, remembering that all flesh will die. Offer a hymn to the Lord, who provides good and helpful things to all people. [45] Examine the Lord's judgments, and so you will let it go, and your mind will be quiet. [46] If someone does get rich from evil, like Esau, my father's brother, do not be jealous; wait for the Lord's limit. [47] For either he takes those things away from him in misfortune, or he forgives the repentant, or he keeps punishment forever for the unrepentant. [48] The poor person who has plenty, giving thanks to the Lord in all things, is rich in every way, because he does not have the evil distraction of people. [49] So remove hatred from your souls, and love one another with uprightness of heart."

Chapter 8 (verses 50–54 here) [50] "Tell these things also to your children, so that they will honor Judah and Levi, for from them the Lord will raise up a savior for Israel. [51] I know that in the end your children will fall away from them, and will be before the Lord in all wickedness, ill-treatment, and corruption." [52] After resting a little, he said to them again, "My children, obey your father, and bury me near my fathers." [53] He stretched out his feet and fell asleep in peace. [54] Five years later they carried him up and laid him in Hebron with his fathers.

Notes

- a (9:1) "Gad" (Hebrew *Gad*) means "good fortune" (Gen 30:11).
- b (9:3) "Two stadia." A stadion was about 607 feet (185 m), so two stadia is about 1,200 feet, or about 0.23 mile (370 m).

Chapter 10

The Testament of Asher, on the Two Faces of Vice and Virtue

Chapter 1 (verses 1–9 here) [1] A copy of the testament of Asher,[a] what he said to his sons in the hundred and twentieth year of his life. [2] While he was still in good health, he said to them, "Listen, children of Asher, to your father, and I will show you everything that is right before God. [3] God has given the sons of men two ways, two inclinations, two kinds of action, two places, and two ends. [4] So all things are two, one set against the other. [5] There are two ways, of good and of evil; and in our chests are the two inclinations that distinguish between

them. [6] If the soul wants to go the good way, every action of it is in righteousness, and if it sins, it repents at once. [7] For by thinking just thoughts and throwing away wickedness, it immediately overturns evil and uproots sin. [8] But if the inclination leans toward evil, every action of it is in wickedness; it pushes good away and takes evil in; it is ruled by Beliar, and even if it does something good, it twists it into wickedness. [9] When it begins as if doing good, the end of its action drives it to do evil, because the treasury of the devil is full of the poison of an evil spirit."

Chapter 2 (verses 10–19 here) [10] "There is a soul, he says, that speaks the good in place of the evil, and yet leads the end of the matter into badness. [11] There is a person who has no pity on someone who serves him in evil; this too is two-faced, but the whole is evil. [12] There is a person who loves the one who does evil; he too is in wickedness, since he chooses even to die in evil for him. It is clear that this too is two-faced, but the whole is a bad action. [13] Even where there is love, it is wickedness if it hides the evil; it is good in name, as it were, but the end of the action comes to evil. [14] Another steals, wrongs, robs, and is greedy, and yet has mercy on the poor; this too is two-faced, but the whole is evil. [15] Someone who cheats his neighbor angers God, perjures himself against the Most High, and yet has mercy on the poor; he rejects and provokes the Lord who gave the commandment of the law, and gives rest to the needy; [16] he stains the soul and makes the body shine; he kills many and shows mercy to few. This too is two-faced. [17] Another commits adultery and sexual immorality, and stays away from rich foods; when he fasts, he does evil; with power and wealth he sweeps many away, and out of his swollen wickedness he keeps commandments. This too is two-faced, but the whole is evil. [18] People like this are like swine and hares, because they are half clean, but in truth they are unclean. [19] For so God has said, on the tablets of heaven."

Chapter 3 (verses 20–21 here) [20] "So you, my children, do not be two-faced like them, partly good and partly bad; hold only to goodness, because God rests in it, and people long for it; [21] run away from wickedness, destroying the devil by your good actions. For the two-

faced do not serve God but their own desires, in order to please Beliar and people like themselves."

Chapter 4 (verses 22–26 here) [22] "Good people who are single-faced, even if they are thought by the two-faced to sin, are righteous before God. [23] Many who kill the wicked do two works, an evil through a good, but the whole is good, because by uprooting the evil he has destroyed it. [24] There is someone who hates the merciful person and wrongs the adulterer and the robber; this too looks two-faced, but the whole work is good, because he imitates the Lord by not accepting what seems good together with real evil. [25] Another does not want to see a good day with the wasteful, so that he does not defile his mouth and pollute his soul. This too looks two-faced, but the whole is good, [26] because such people are like roe deer and deer: in a wild way of life they seem unclean, but they are entirely clean, because they walk in zeal for God, staying away from what God also hates and forbids by his commands, keeping evil away from the good."

Chapter 5 (verses 27–30 here) [27] "See, then, children, how there are two in everything, one set against the other, and one hidden by the other. [28] Death follows life, dishonor follows glory, night follows day, and darkness follows light; but all things are under the day, and just things under life; therefore eternal life also awaits death. [29] It is not possible to call truth a lie, or the just unjust; for all truth is under the light, as all things are under God. [30] I have tested all this in my life, and I have not strayed from the truth of the Lord, and I have sought out the commands of the Most High, walking with all my strength single-facedly toward the good."

Chapter 6 (verses 31–36 here) [31] "So you too, children, pay attention to the commands of the Lord, following the truth single-facedly, [32] for the two-faced are punished twice. Hate the spirits of error that fight against a person. [33] Keep the law of the Lord, and do not treat evil as good; look instead to what is truly good, and keep it in all the Lord's commands, turning to him and finding rest in him, [34] because the ends of people show their righteousness, and make known the angels of the Lord and of Satan. [35] If the soul leaves in turmoil, it is tormented by the evil spirit it served in desires and evil deeds; [36] but if it leaves

quietly, in joy, it has known the angel of peace, and he will comfort it in life."

Chapter 7 (verses 37–43 here) [37] "Do not be, children, like Sodom, which did not recognize the angels of the Lord and was destroyed forever. [38] I know that you will sin and be handed over into the hands of your enemies; your land will be laid waste, and you will be scattered to the four corners of the earth, and in the dispersion you will be despised like worthless water, [39] until the Most High visits the earth; coming himself as a man, eating and drinking with people, and quietly crushing the head of the dragon through water. He will save Israel and all the nations, God disguised as a man. [40] So tell your children these things, so that they will not disobey him. [41] For I read on the tablets of heaven that you will certainly disobey him and certainly act ungodly toward him, not paying attention to the law of God but to the commands of people. [42] For this reason you will be scattered, like Gad and Dan my brothers, who will not know their land, tribe, or language. [43] But the Lord will gather you in faith, through the hope of his compassion, for the sake of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob."

Chapter 8 (verses 44–45 here) [44] After telling them these things, he commanded them, saying, "Bury me in Hebron." And he died, falling asleep in a good sleep; [45] and after this his sons did as he had commanded them, and carried him up and buried him with his fathers.

Notes

- a (10:1) "Asher" (Hebrew *Asher*) means "happy" or "fortunate" (Gen 30:13).

Chapter 11

The Testament of Joseph, on Self-Control

Chapter 1 (verses 1–7 here) [1] A copy of the testament of Joseph.[a] When he was about to die, he called his sons and his brothers and said to them, [2] "My children and brothers, listen to Joseph, beloved of Israel; give ear, sons, to your father. [3] In my life I have seen envy and death, and I did not stray from the truth of the Lord. [4] These brothers of mine hated me, and the Lord loved me; they wanted to kill me, and the God of my fathers kept me safe; they lowered me into a pit, and the Most High brought me up; [5] I was sold as a slave, and the Lord freed me; I

was taken into captivity, and his strong hand helped me; I was held in hunger, and the Lord himself fed me; [6] I was alone, and God comforted me; I was sick, and the Most High visited me; I was in prison, and the Savior showed me favor; I was in chains, and he released me; [7] I was under slander, and he pleaded my case; I was under the bitter words of the Egyptians, and he rescued me; I was among envies and deceits, and he lifted me up."

Chapter 2 (verses 8–14 here) [8] "So Photimar, the chief cook of Pharaoh, entrusted his house to me. [9] I struggled against a shameless woman who pressed me to break the law with her; but the God of Israel my father kept me from a blazing flame. [10] I was imprisoned, beaten, and mocked; and the Lord gave me pity in the eyes of the prison keeper. [11] For he will never abandon those who fear him, not in darkness, nor in chains, nor in afflictions, nor in hardships. [12] God is not ashamed like a human being, he does not shrink back like a son of man, he does not grow weak or give up like one born of the earth; [13] he stands by in every place, and he comforts in different ways, withdrawing for a short time in order to test the purpose of the soul. [14] He showed me to be approved in ten trials, and in all of them I was patient; for patience is a great medicine, and endurance gives many good things."

Chapter 3 (verses 15–24 here) [15] "How often did the Egyptian woman threaten me with death! How often, after handing me over to punishment, did she call me back and threaten me when I would not go to bed with her! And she said to me, [16] 'You will rule over me and over everything I have, if you give yourself to me, and you will be our master.' [17] So I remembered the words of the fathers of my father Jacob, and going into my room, I prayed to the Lord, [18] and I fasted during those seven years, and I looked to the Egyptian woman as if I were living in luxury; for those who fast for God gain a gracious face. [19] If she gave me wine, I did not drink; and going without food for three days at a time, I took my meal and gave it to the poor and the sick. [20] I rose early to pray to the Lord, and I wept over Memphia the Egyptian, because she pestered me so constantly; at night she would come to me on the pretext of a visit. [21] At first, because she had no male child, she pretended to take me as her son. I prayed to the Lord,

and she bore a male child. [22] For some time she embraced me as a son, and I did not realize; but in the end she was drawing me into sexual immorality. [23] When I understood, I was grieved to the point of death. When she left, I came to myself, and I mourned over her for many days, because I knew her deceit and her error. [24] I spoke to her the words of the Most High, in case she would turn away from her wicked desire."

Chapter 4 (verses 25–32 here) [25] "How often did she flatter me with words, as if I were a holy man, deceitfully praising my self-control in front of her husband, but wanting to trip me alone! [26] She praised me openly as self-controlled, and secretly said to me, 'Do not be afraid of my husband; he is convinced about your self-control, and even if someone tells him about us, he will not believe it.' [27] Through all this I lay on the ground in sackcloth and begged God that the Lord would rescue me from the Egyptian woman. [28] When she accomplished nothing, she came to me again on the pretext of instruction, to learn the word of the Lord. [29] She said to me, 'If you want me to leave my idols, be persuaded by me; and I will persuade the Egyptian to give up his idols, so that we may walk in the law of your Lord.' [30] I said to her, 'The Lord does not say that those who revere him are in uncleanness, and he takes no pleasure in adulterers.' [31] She fell silent, longing to carry out her desire. [32] I added fasting and prayer, so that the Lord would rescue me from her."

Chapter 5 (verses 33–36 here) [33] "At another time she said to me, 'If you do not want to commit adultery, I will kill the Egyptian, and then I will take you lawfully as my husband.' [34] When I heard this, I tore my robe and said, 'Woman, respect the Lord and do not do this wicked deed, or you will be destroyed; I will even tell everyone about your plan of ungodliness.' [35] Frightened, she begged me not to tell anyone of her wickedness. [36] And she went away, trying to warm me with gifts, and sending me every pleasure of the sons of men."

Chapter 6 (verses 37–45 here) [37] "She sent me food mixed with sorcery. [38] When the eunuch who brought it came, I looked up and saw a fearsome man handing me a sword along with the dish. I understood that her scheme was meant to lead my soul astray. [39] When he left,

I wept, and tasted neither that food nor any of her dainties. [40] After a day she came to me, recognized the food, and said to me, 'Why is it that you did not eat any of the food?' [41] I said to her, 'Because you filled it with death. How could you say that you do not approach idols, but only the Lord? [42] Now know that the God of my father revealed your wickedness to me through an angel, and I kept the food to show you your guilt, in case you would see it and repent. [43] So that you may learn that the wickedness of the ungodly does not overpower those who worship God in self-control, I took it in front of her and ate, saying, "The God of my fathers and the angel of Abraham will be with me."' [44] She fell on her face at my feet and wept. I raised her up and warned her, [45] and she promised not to do this ungodly act again."

Chapter 7 (verses 46–53 here) [46] "But since her heart was set on me for indulgence, she kept falling at my feet, groaning. [47] When the Egyptian husband saw her, he said to her, 'Why has your face fallen?' She said, 'I have a pain in my heart, and the groans of my spirit are holding me.' And he tended her though she was not ill. [48] Then she jumped at me while her husband was still outside, and said to me, 'I will hang myself, or throw myself into a well or off a cliff, unless you are persuaded by me.' [49] Understanding that the spirit of Beliar was troubling her, I prayed to the Lord and said to her, [50] 'Why are you troubled and in an uproar, blinded by your sins? Remember that if you kill yourself, Sethon, your husband's concubine and your rival, will beat your children and wipe out your memory from the earth.' [51] She said to me, 'See, then, you love me. It is enough for me that you care about my life and my children's. I expect to enjoy my desire.' [52] She did not know that I spoke this way because of my God, and not because of her. [53] For if someone falls under the passion of an evil desire and is enslaved to it, as she was, even if he hears something good, he takes it as it applies to the passion that has beaten him, toward evil desire."

Chapter 8 (verses 54–58 here) [54] "I tell you, children, it was about noon[b] when she left me; and I knelt before the Lord the whole day and into the whole night, and toward dawn I rose in tears, asking for rescue from the Egyptian woman. [55] In the end she took hold of my clothes and dragged me by force to lie with her. [56] When I saw that in her

frenzy she held my clothes by force, I fled naked. [57] She slandered me to her husband; and the Egyptian put me in prison in his house, and the next day he flogged me and sent me to the prison in his house. [58] While I was in chains, the Egyptian woman became ill from grief, and listened to me singing to the Lord in the house of darkness, rejoicing in a glad voice and glorifying my God, only because I had a reason to be free of the Egyptian woman."

Chapter 9 (verses 59–63 here) [59] "She often sent to me, saying, 'Agree to fulfill my desire, and I will free you from your chains and take you out of the darkness.' [60] I never bent toward her even in thought. For God loves the one who fasts in self-control in a pit of darkness more than the one who lives in luxury in the inner rooms with indulgence. [61] The one who lives in self-control also wants glory, and if the Most High knows it is good for him, he provides this too, as he did for me. [62] How often, though she was ill, did she come down to me at an untimely hour and hear my voice praying! When I understood her groans, I kept silent. [63] When I was in her house, she would uncover her arms, chest, and legs, so that I would fall for her; for she was very beautiful, especially when dressed up to trick me. But the Lord kept me from her attempts."

Chapter 10 (verses 64–69 here) [64] "See, then, my children, how much patience accomplishes, and prayer with fasting. [65] You too, if you pursue self-control and purity with patience and humility of heart, the Lord will live in you, because he loves self-control. [66] Where the Most High lives, even if someone falls into envy, slavery, or slander, the Lord who lives in him, because of his self-control, not only rescues him from evil, but also lifts him up and glorifies him, as he did me. [67] Every person is held in some way, either in deed, in word, or in thought. [68] My brothers know how my father loved me; and I was not lifted up in my heart. Although I was a child, I had the fear of God in my mind, for I knew that everything will pass away, [69] and I measured myself and honored my brothers. Out of respect for them I kept silent while being sold, and did not tell the Ishmaelites my family, that I am the son of Jacob, a great and powerful man."

Chapter 11 (verses 70–77 here) [70] "You too, then, have the fear of God in your actions and honor your brothers. Everyone who keeps the law of the Lord will be loved by him. [71] When I came to the Indocolpites with the Ishmaelites, they asked me; and I said that I was their slave, born in their house, so that I would not shame my brothers. [72] The eldest of them said to me, 'You are not a slave, for your face shows what you are'; and he threatened me with death. But I kept saying that I was their slave. [73] When we came to Egypt, they fought over me, over who would give gold to get me. [74] So everyone decided that I would stay in Egypt with a trader of theirs until they came back bringing merchandise. [75] The Lord gave me favor in the eyes of the trader, and he entrusted his house to me. [76] The Lord blessed him by my hand, and made him rich in silver and gold; [77] and I was with him three months and five days."

Chapter 12 (verses 78–80 here) [78] "At that time Memphia, the wife of Potiphar,[c] came by with great splendor, and set her eyes on me, because the eunuchs had told her about me. [79] She told her husband about the trader, that he had grown rich through a young Hebrew; and she said, 'They say they stole him by theft from the land of Canaan. [80] Now hold a trial with him, and take the young man for your steward; and the God of the Hebrews will bless you, because heavenly grace is on him.'"

Chapter 13 (verses 81–89 here) [81] "Potiphar, persuaded by her words, ordered the trader to be brought and said to him, 'What is this I hear, that you are stealing people from the land of the Hebrews and selling them as slaves?' [82] The trader fell on his face and begged, saying, 'I beg you, my lord, I do not know what you are saying.' [83] He said, 'Then where did you get the Hebrew boy?' He answered, 'The Ishmaelites left him with me until they come back.' [84] He did not believe him, but ordered him to be beaten naked. When he held to his story, Potiphar said, 'Bring the young man.' [85] I was brought in and bowed to the chief eunuch; for he was third in rank under Pharaoh, a ruler over all the eunuchs, with a wife, children, and concubines. [86] He separated me from the trader and said to me, 'Are you a slave or free?' I said, 'A slave.' [87] He said to me, 'Whose slave?' I said, 'The Ishmaelites'.' [88]

Again he said to me, ‘How did you become their slave?’ I said that they had bought me in Canaan. [89] He did not believe it, saying, ‘You are lying’; and he ordered me beaten naked.”

Chapter 14 (verses 90–95 here) [90] “Memphia saw through a window that I was being beaten, and sent word to her husband, saying, ‘Your judgment is unjust, because you punish a free person who was stolen, as if he had done wrong.’ [91] When I did not change my story under the beating, he ordered me imprisoned, until, he said, the boy’s owners came. [92] His wife said to him, ‘Why do you hold the captive, a boy of noble birth, who ought rather to be free and to serve you?’ [93] She wanted to see me in longing for sin; and in all this I did not realize it. [94] He said to Memphia, ‘Among the Egyptians it is not the custom to take away another’s property before there is proof.’ [95] He said this about the trader, and about me, that I should be locked up.”

Chapter 15 (verses 96–102 here) [96] “After twenty-four days the Ishmaelites came; and having heard that Jacob my father was mourning over me, they said to me, [97] ‘Why did you say you were a slave? We have found that you are the son of a great man in Canaan, and your father is mourning for you in a pit.’ [98] I wanted to weep again, but held myself back so that I would not shame my brothers. And I said, ‘I do not know; I am a slave.’ [99] Then they planned to sell me, so that I would not be found in their hands. [100] They were afraid of Jacob, that he would take revenge on them with danger; for it was said that he is great with the Lord and with people. [101] Then the trader said to them, ‘Free me from the judgment of Potiphar.’ [102] They came and asked me for it, saying, ‘He was bought by us with silver, and he let us go.’”

Chapter 16 (verses 103–108 here) [103] “Memphia told her husband to buy me, saying, ‘I hear they are selling him.’ [104] He sent a eunuch to the Ishmaelites, asking to buy me; [105] and when they did not want to deal with him, he withdrew. The eunuch, having tried them, told his mistress that they were asking a high price for the boy. [106] She sent another eunuch, saying, ‘Even if they ask for two and a half pounds[d] of gold, take care not to spare the gold; just buy the boy and bring him.’ [107] She gave them eighty gold pieces for me, and told the Egyptian

woman's husband that a hundred had been given for me. [108] When I saw this, I kept silent, so that the eunuch would not be questioned."
Chapter 17 (verses 109–116 here) [109] "See, children, how much I endured so as not to shame my brothers. [110] You too, love one another, and in patience cover over one another's faults. [111] For God is pleased with harmony among brothers, and with a choice of heart that is content with love. [112] When my brothers came into Egypt and learned that I had returned their silver to them, and I did not reproach them but comforted them, [113] and after Jacob's death I loved them even more, and I did everything he commanded and more, and they were amazed. [114] I did not let them be distressed over even a small thing; whatever was in my hand, I gave to them. [115] Their sons were my sons, and my sons were like their servants; their soul was my soul, every pain of theirs my pain, and every sickness of theirs my sickness; my land was theirs, my counsel theirs. [116] I did not exalt myself over them in boasting because of my worldly glory, but was among them as one of the least."
Chapter 18 (verses 117–120 here) [117] "So if you too walk in the commands of the Lord, my children, he will lift you up here, and will bless you with good things forever. [118] If anyone wants to do you evil, do good and pray for him; and you will be rescued from every evil through the Lord. [119] See that because of my patience I even took a daughter of my lords as a wife, and 7,500 pounds of gold[e] were given to me with her; for the Lord made them serve me. [120] He gave me beauty, like a flower above the beautiful ones of Israel; and he kept me to old age in strength and beauty, for I was like Jacob in everything."
Chapter 19 (verses 121–127 here) [121] "Listen, my children, to the dreams I saw. [122] Twelve deer were grazing, and nine of them were divided and scattered over the earth; likewise the three. [123] I saw that from Judah was born a virgin, wearing a linen robe; and from her came a spotless lamb, and on his left something like a lion; and all the wild animals rushed against him, and the lamb overcame them and destroyed them, to be trampled. [124] The angels rejoiced over him, and the people, and all the earth. [125] These things will happen in their time, in the last days. [126] So you, my children, keep the commands of the Lord, and

honor Judah and Levi; for from them the Lamb of God will rise for you, saving all the nations and Israel by grace. [127] For his kingdom is an everlasting kingdom that will not be shaken; but my kingdom among you will come to an end, like a fruit-watchman's hut, which is not seen after summer."

Chapter 20 (verses 128–133 here) [128] "I know that after my death the Egyptians will oppress you; but God will take vengeance for you and bring you into the promise of your fathers. [129] But you must carry my bones up with you, for when my bones are taken up, the Lord will be with you in light, and Beliar will be in darkness with the Egyptians. [130] Take your mother Zilpah too, and lay her near Bilhah, by the Hippodrome, close to Rachel." [131] After saying this, he stretched out his feet and fell asleep with the sleep of eternity. [132] All Israel mourned him, and all of Egypt with a great mourning. [133] For he had shared the suffering of the Egyptians as if they were his own limbs, and had done them good, standing with them in every work, plan, and matter.

Notes

- a (11:1) "Joseph" (Hebrew *Yosef*) means "may he add," from Gen 30:24, "May Yahweh add to me another son."
- b (11:54) The Greek says "about the sixth hour," counted from sunrise, which is about noon.
- c (11:78) "Potiphar" (Hebrew *Potifar*) is from an Egyptian name meaning "the one whom Ra gave." The Greek spells it "Petephri" or "Petephris."
- d (11:106) "Two minas." A mina was one-sixtieth of a talent, about 1.25 pounds (0.57 kg), so two minas is about 2.5 pounds (1.1 kg) of gold.
- e (11:119) "A hundred talents." A talent was about 75 pounds (34 kg), so a hundred talents is about 7,500 pounds (3,400 kg).

Chapter 12

The Testament of Benjamin, on the Good Mind

Chapter 1 (verses 1–6 here) [1] A copy of the words of Benjamin,[a] which he laid down for his sons, having lived a hundred and twenty years. [2] He kissed them and said, "As Isaac was born to Abraham in his hundredth year, so I was to Jacob. [3] Since Rachel died giving birth to me, I had no milk, and so I was nursed by her maid Bilhah. [4] For after bearing Joseph Rachel was barren for twelve years; she prayed to the Lord with fasting for twelve days; and then she conceived and

bore me. [5] Our father loved Rachel very much, and prayed to see two sons from her. [6] For this reason I was called 'son of days,' which is Benjamin."

Chapter 2 (verses 7–11 here) [7] "When I came into Egypt and my brother Joseph recognized me, he said to me, 'What did you tell my father when they sold me?' [8] I told him they had smeared your tunic with blood and sent it, saying, 'See whether this is your son's tunic.' [9] He said to me, 'Yes, brother; for when the Ishmaelites took me, one of them stripped off my tunic, gave me a loincloth, flogged me, and told me to run. [10] As he went off to hide my cloak, a lion met him and killed him. [11] So his companions were frightened and sold me on to others.'"

Chapter 3 (verses 12–19 here) [12] "So you too, my children, love the Lord, the God of heaven, and keep his commands, imitating the good and holy man Joseph. [13] Let your mind be set on the good, as you know I have been. Whoever has a good mind sees everything rightly. [14] Fear the Lord and love your neighbor; and if the spirits of Beliar demand you for every kind of affliction, no wickedness of affliction will overpower you, just as it did not overpower my brother Joseph. [15] How many people wanted to kill him, and God protected him! For the one who fears God and loves his neighbor cannot be struck by the airy spirit of Beliar, being covered by the fear of God; [16] and he cannot be overpowered by the plots of people or of wild animals, being helped by the Lord's love, which he has for his neighbor. [17] I begged our father Jacob to pray for our brothers, that the Lord would not count against them whatever evil they had thought against him. [18] Jacob cried out, 'O my child Joseph, you have overcome the heart of Jacob your father.' He embraced him, and for two hours kissed him, saying, [19] 'The prophecy of heaven about the Lamb of God and Savior of the world will be fulfilled in you: that a spotless one will be handed over for the lawless, and a sinless one will die for the ungodly, in the blood of a covenant, for the salvation of the nations and of Israel, and he will destroy Beliar and those who serve him.'"

Chapter 4 (verses 20–24 here) [20] "Have you seen, children, the end of the good man? Imitate his compassion with a good mind, so that you too may wear crowns of glory. [21] The good man does not have a dark eye;

for he has mercy on all, even if they are sinners, [22] even if they plot evil against him. So the one who does good overcomes evil, covered by the good; and he loves the righteous as his own soul. [23] If someone is honored, he is not envious; if someone is rich, he is not jealous; if someone is brave, he praises him; he trusts and sings the praise of the self-controlled; he has mercy on the poor; he sympathizes with the weak; he sings praise to God; [24] he defends the one who has the fear of God; he works with the one who loves God; the one who rejects the Most High he warns and turns back, and the one who has the grace of a good spirit he loves as his own soul."

Chapter 5 (verses 25–29 here) [25] "If you have a good mind, children, even evil people will be at peace with you, the wasteful will respect you and turn to good, and the greedy will not only give up their passion but will even give what they got by greed to the afflicted. [26] If you keep doing good, even the unclean spirits will flee from you, and the wild animals themselves will flee from you in fear. [27] For where there is the fear of good works in the mind, darkness runs away from it. [28] If someone insults a holy man, he repents; for the holy man has mercy on the abuser, and is silent. [29] And if someone betrays a righteous soul, and the righteous one prays and is humbled for a little while, he afterward appears much brighter, as my brother Joseph did."

Chapter 6 (verses 30–36 here) [30] "The plan of the good man is not in the hand of the spirit of error, Beliar; for the angel of peace guides his soul. [31] He does not look with passion at perishable things, or gather wealth for the love of pleasure. [32] He does not delight in pleasure, does not hurt his neighbor, is not stuffed with food, and is not led astray by raising his eyes; for the Lord is his portion. [33] The good mind does not accept the glory and dishonor of human beings, and knows no deceit or lie, no fighting or abuse. For the Lord lives in it, lights up its soul, and it rejoices toward everyone at all times. [34] The good mind does not have two tongues, of blessing and cursing, of insult and honor, of sadness and joy, of quiet and disturbance, of hypocrisy and truth, of poverty and wealth; it has one single pure and sincere attitude toward everyone. [35] It has no double sight or hearing; for in everything it does, says, or sees, it knows that the Lord is watching over its soul, [36] and

cleansing its mind, so that it will not be condemned by God or people. Every work of Beliar is double, and has no simplicity."

Chapter 7 (verses 37–41 here) [37] "So, my children, flee the wickedness of Beliar, because he gives a sword to those who obey him. [38] The sword is the mother of seven evils. First the mind conceives through Beliar; the first is envy; the second, destruction; the third, affliction; the fourth, captivity; the fifth, want; the sixth, disorder; the seventh, desolation. [39] For this reason Cain was also handed over by God to seven punishments; for every hundred years the Lord brought one blow on him. [40] He suffered for two hundred years, and in the nine hundredth year he was made desolate, at the flood, because of Abel his righteous brother. In his seven hundred years Cain was judged, and Lamech in seventy times seven; [41] for forever, those who become like Cain in envy, to the point of hating their brothers, will be judged by the same punishment."

Chapter 8 (verses 42–44 here) [42] "So you too, my children, run away from wickedness, envy, and hatred of brothers, and cling to goodness and love. [43] The one who has a pure mind in love does not look at a woman for sexual immorality; for he has no pollution in his heart, because the Spirit of God rests in him. [44] Just as the sun is not polluted by shining on dung and mud, but instead dries both and drives away the stench, so the pure mind, held among the pollutions of the earth, rather builds up, and is not itself polluted."

Chapter 9 (verses 45–49 here) [45] "I suspect that there will be actions among you that are not good, from the words of Enoch the righteous. You will commit the sexual immorality of Sodom, and be destroyed, all but a few, and renew wantonness with women; and the kingdom of the Lord will not be among you, for he will take it away at once. [46] Yet in your portion the temple of God will be built, and it will be glorious among you. For he will take it, and the twelve tribes will be gathered there, and all the nations, until the Most High sends his salvation, in the visitation of an only-begotten one. [47] He will go into the first temple, and there the Lord will be insulted and despised, and lifted up on a tree. [48] The curtain of the temple will be torn, and the Spirit of God will pass on to the nations, like fire poured out. [49] Having

come up out of Hades, he will go up from earth to heaven. I know how humble he will be on earth, and how glorious in heaven."

Chapter 10 (verses 50–60 here) [50] "When Joseph was in Egypt, I longed to see his appearance and the shape of his face; and through the prayers of Jacob my father I saw him, awake, in the daytime, just as his whole appearance was. [51] Know, then, my children, that I am dying. [52] So practice truth and righteousness, each with his neighbor, and justice for confirmation, and keep the law of the Lord and his commands; [53] for these things I teach you in place of every inheritance. So give them to your children, too, as an everlasting possession. For Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob did this. [54] All these things they left us as an inheritance, saying, 'Keep the commands of God, until the Lord reveals his salvation to all the nations.' [55] Then you will see Enoch, Noah, Shem, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob rising on the right hand, in joy. [56] Then we too will rise, each at our scepter, worshiping the King of heaven, who appeared on earth in the form of a man of humility. All who believed in him on earth will rejoice with him. [57] Then everyone will rise, some to glory and some to dishonor. The Lord will judge Israel first for its wrong against him, because they did not believe in God who came in flesh as deliverer. [58] Then he will judge all the nations, as many as did not believe in him when he appeared on earth; [59] and he will convict Israel among the chosen of the nations, as he convicted Esau among the Midianites, who deceived their brothers into sexual immorality and idolatry; they were estranged from God, becoming not children in the portion of those who fear the Lord. [60] But if you walk in holiness in the sight of the Lord, you will again live in hope in me; and all Israel will be gathered to the Lord."

Chapter 11 (verses 61–65 here) [61] "No longer will I be called a ravening wolf because of your plundering, but a worker of the Lord, handing out food to those who do good. [62] In later times there will rise from my seed one beloved of the Lord, hearing his voice on earth, enlightening all the nations with new knowledge, a light of knowledge stepping into Israel for salvation; he will snatch from it like a wolf and give to the assembly of the nations. [63] Until the end of the ages he will be in the assemblies of the nations and among their rulers, like a musical

tune in the mouth of all; [64] and he will be written about in holy books, both his work and his word; and he will be God's chosen one forever; [65] and because of him Jacob my father instructed me, saying, 'He will fill up what is lacking in your tribe.'"

Chapter 12 (verses 66–69 here) [66] When he had finished his words, he said, "I command you, my children, to carry my bones up from Egypt and bury me in Hebron, near my fathers." [67] Benjamin died at the age of a hundred and twenty-five, in a good old age; and they placed him in a coffin. [68] In the ninety-first year after the Exodus of the sons of Israel from Egypt, they and their brothers carried up the bones of their fathers secretly, to the place called Canaan; and they buried them in Hebron, at the feet of their fathers. [69] Then they returned from the land of Canaan and lived in Egypt until the day of their departure from the land of Egypt.

Notes

- a (12:1) "Benjamin" (Hebrew *Binyamin*) is usually explained as "son of the right hand" or "son of the south" (Gen 35:18). This book explains it as "son of days" (1.6).

Psalms of Solomon

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

A psalm of Solomon.

1 I cried out to the Lord in my distress,
to God, when sinners attacked.
2 All at once the sound of war was in my ears,
and I said, "He will hear me, since I am filled with righteousness."
3 I assumed in my own mind that I was full of righteousness,
because I was doing well and had many children.
4 Their wealth spread over the whole earth,
and their fame reached the ends of the earth.
5 They rose as high as the stars;
they claimed, "They can never fall."
6 But they grew insolent in their good fortune and could not bear it,
and their sins were done in secret, and I did not know them.
7 Their lawless deeds went beyond those of the nations before them;
they completely desecrated what belongs to the Lord.
8 They grew proud over everything, and their sins were many.[b]

Notes

- a (1:title) Greek *Psalmos tō Salomōn*. The title is attached to nearly every psalm in the collection. Psalm 1 has no title in the oldest Greek manuscripts and may have been added later; the ascription to Solomon is traditional and is not meant literally. See the introduction above.
- b (1:8) The verse numbering of this book follows Swete's Greek text (which is that of Gebhardt, 1895, and of Ryle and James, 1891). Modern translations that follow Rahlfs's edition (1935) number the verses differently in several psalms, so references may differ by a few verses.

Chapter 2

A psalm of Solomon, about Jerusalem.

1 When the sinner grew arrogant, he knocked down fortified walls with a battering ram,
and you did not stop him.
2 Foreign nations went up to your altar;
they trampled it arrogantly, with their sandals on,
3 because the sons of Jerusalem had made the Lord's sacred things unclean;
they had desecrated the offerings made to God by their lawless acts.
4 For this reason he said, "Throw them far away from me."
The beauty of his glory was of no benefit to them.[b]
5 It was despised before God;
it was utterly dishonored.
6 Sons and daughters went into a wretched captivity;
their necks were sealed, and they were marked out among the nations.
7 He treated them according to their sins,
because he abandoned them into the hands of the powerful.
8 For he turned his face away from pitying them,
young and old and their children alike.
9 For they had done evil all together,
so as not to listen.
10 The heaven was angry,
and the earth detested them,
11 because no one on earth had ever done
what they did.
12 So the earth will recognize all your judgments, God, as just.
13 They set the sons of Jerusalem up as a laughingstock
in place of its prostitutes;[c]
everyone who passed by went in under the sun's eye.
14 They made fun of their lawless acts, as they themselves used to do;
they put their wrongdoing on public display in the face of the sun.

15 Because these women defiled themselves in a confusion of mixed unions,
my belly and my inward parts ache over this.
16 I will declare you righteous, God, with an upright heart,
for your righteousness lies in your judgments, God.
17 For you paid sinners back according to their deeds,
and according to their sins, which were very wicked.
18 You uncovered their sins so that your judgment would be seen;
19 you wiped out their memory from the earth.
God is a just judge, and no one's appearance impresses him.[d]
20 For the nations reproached Jerusalem by trampling her down;
her beauty was dragged down from the throne of glory.
21 She put on sackcloth in place of her fine robe,
a rope around her head in place of a crown.
22 She was stripped of the turban of glory
which God had put on her;
23 in dishonor her beauty was thrown to the ground.
24 And I looked, and pleaded before the face of the Lord, and said:
"Enough, Lord, of your hand weighing heavily on Israel,
by bringing the nations against it.
25 For they have mocked and have shown no mercy,
in anger and rage and bitter fury,
26 and they will make an end of us,
unless you, Lord, rebuke them in your anger.
27 For they have not acted out of zeal,
but out of the desire of their soul,
28 to pour out their anger on us in plunder.
29 Do not delay, God, to repay them on their heads,
to speak against the dragon's pride
in a single charge."[e]
30 I did not have to wait long before God showed me his arrogance:
pierced through on the mountains of Egypt,
of less account than the least of men on land and sea.[f]

31 His body was carried to and fro on the waves in great disgrace,
and there was no one to bury him.
32 For he had treated others with contempt, in dishonor;
he did not reckon that he was a man,
and did not think of what comes afterward.
33 He said, "I shall be master of land and sea,"
and he did not realize that God is great,
powerful in his enormous might.
34 He himself is king over the heavens,
and judges kings and rulers.
35 It is he who raises me to glory,
and who puts the proud to sleep in everlasting destruction and dishonor,
because they did not know him.
36 And now, you magnates of the earth, behold the Lord's judgment:
he is a mighty and righteous king,
who judges all that lies under the sky.
37 Praise God, you who revere the Lord with knowledge,
for the Lord's mercy rests on those who revere him,
and comes along with his verdict,
38 to separate the righteous from the sinner,
and to repay sinners forever according to their deeds,
39 and to have mercy on the righteous, away from the humiliation by the sinner,
and to repay the sinner for what he did to the righteous.
40 For the Lord is good to those who call on him with patience,
to act according to his mercy toward his devout ones,
and to let them stand before him continually in strength.
41 Blessed be the Lord forever in the presence of his servants.

Notes

- a (2:title) Jerusalem is probably "foundation of Shalem" or "city of peace," but the origin of the name is uncertain.
- b (2:4) "His glory" here is probably the glory of God dwelling in the temple.

- c (2:13) Greek *pornai*, "prostitutes." Verses 13–14 are obscure; the idea seems to be that the Gentile soldiers treated the city's people as they would treat prostitutes, openly, in daylight.
- d (2:19) That is, he shows no partiality (compare Deut 10:17).
- e (2:29) The Greek of this verse is hard and probably damaged, and a few manuscripts read differently. "The dragon" is the foreign conqueror of verse 1, whom most scholars identify with the Roman general Pompey (who took Jerusalem in 63 BC); compare Jer 51:34 and Ezek 29:3. His death is described in verses 30–31.
- f (2:30) Pompey was murdered on the Egyptian shore in 48 BC after his defeat by Julius Caesar; his body was left on the beach and cremated by a freedman. The psalm does not name him.

Chapter 3

A psalm of Solomon, about the righteous.

1 Why are you sleeping, my soul, and not blessing the Lord?
2 Sing a hymn, a new song, to God who is worthy of praise.
Sing and be wide awake at his watch,
for a psalm to God from a good heart is good.[a]
3 The righteous always remember the Lord,
in confession and in declaring the Lord's judgments to be right.
4 The righteous do not make light of the Lord's discipline,
and their good will is always before the Lord.
5 The righteous stumble and they declare the Lord just;
they fall and look to see what God will do for them;

6 they look out from where their rescue will come.
7 The confidence of the righteous is from God their savior.
Sin upon sin does not lodge in the house of a righteous man.
8 The righteous constantly looks over his house,
to remove any wrong done by his own transgression.
9 He makes atonement for sins of ignorance by fasting and humbling his soul,
10 and the Lord cleanses every devout man and his household.
11 The sinner stumbles and curses his life,
the day he was born and the pains of his mother's labor.
12 He adds sins to sins as long as he lives.

13 He falls, for his fall is evil, and he will not get up;
the destruction of the sinner is forever,
14 and he will not be remembered when God visits the righteous.
15 This is the portion of sinners forever.
16 But those who fear the Lord will rise up to eternal life,
and their life will be in the Lord's light, which will never come to an end.

Notes

- a (3:2) "Watch" translates Greek *egrēgorsis*, "wakefulness"; it may refer to the night watches, or to the stations at which singers and watchmen served in the temple.

Chapter 4

Solomon's dialogue with the people-pleasers.

1 Why do you sit, you profane man, in the council of the devout,
while your heart is far away from the Lord,
angering the God of Israel with your lawless acts?
2 Excessive in words, excessive in outward display beyond everyone,
he is harsh in his speech when he condemns sinners in judgment.
3 His hand is the first against them, as though in zeal,
and yet he is himself guilty in many kinds of sin and in lack of self-control.
4 His eyes are on every woman, without distinction;
his tongue lies when he makes a contract with an oath.
5 At night and in secret places he sins as though no one sees him;
with his eyes he talks to every woman in an appointment for wickedness.
6 He is quick to enter every house with a cheerful face, as though he were innocent.
7 May God remove those who live in hypocrisy among the devout,
in the ruin of his flesh and with a life of poverty.
8 May God uncover the works of the people-pleasers,
and may his works become a laughingstock and a mockery.
9 May the devout declare the judgment of their God to be just,
when sinners are removed from the face of the righteous,

10 the people-pleaser who speaks only with deceit.
11 And their eyes are on a man's house in its security, like a snake,
to break up each other's wisdom with the words of lawless men.
12 His words are deceptions,
aiming at the fulfillment of unjust desire.
13 He does not stop until he has succeeded in scattering them as orphans,
and he has made a house desolate for the sake of lawless desire.
14 He deceived them with words, saying that there is no one who sees and judges;
15 he is filled with lawlessness in this,
and his eyes are on another house, to destroy it with words that will fill his appetite.
His soul is never satisfied, like Hades, in all these things.[b]
16 Lord, may his portion be dishonor in your presence;
may he leave with groans and arrive to curses.
17 May his life be in pains and poverty and helplessness, Lord;
may his sleep be in sorrows and his waking in distress.
18 May sleep be taken from his temples at night;
may he fail in every work of his hands, in dishonor.
19 May his house be empty,
lacking everything that would fill his soul,
20 and may his old age be spent in the loneliness of childlessness, until he is taken away.
21 May the flesh of the people-pleasers be torn apart by wild animals,
and the bones of the lawless lie in the sun, in dishonor.
22 May crows pull out the eyes of those who put on a show,
23 because they have laid waste many people's houses in dishonor and scattered them in their greed.
24 They did not remember God,
and they did not fear God in any of this.
25 They provoked God and made him angry, so that he would remove them from the earth,

because they pretended to be on the side of innocent souls, deceiving them.
[26] Blessed are those who fear the Lord in their innocence.
[27] The Lord will rescue them from deceitful men and sinners,
and he will rescue us from every trap of the lawless.
[28] May God remove those who in arrogance do every kind of wrong,
for the Lord our God is a great and mighty judge in righteousness.
[29] Lord, may your mercy be on all who love you.

Notes

- a (4:title) Greek *anthrōparesko*, "those who please men"; compare Col 3:22 and Eph 6:6. The psalm attacks hypocrites, probably the religious and political leaders of the Hasmonean period, who put on a show of devotion.
- b (4:15) Hades (Greek *hadēs*) is the realm of the dead, the Hebrew Sheol, which is never full (Prov 27:20; Hab 2:5).

Chapter 5

A psalm of Solomon.

[1] Lord God, I will praise your name with joy
among those who know your righteous judgments.
[2] For you are kind and merciful,
a refuge for the poor,
[3] so when I cry out to you, do not be silent toward me.
[4] For no one can take plunder away from a powerful man,
[5] and who can take anything from all that you have made, unless you give it?
[6] For a man and his portion are weighed out by you;
he will not add to it, to have more than your judgment allows, God.
[7] When we are afflicted we will call on you for help,
and you will not turn away our plea,
for you are our God.
[8] Do not lay your hand heavily on us,
lest in our need we sin.
[9] Even if you do not turn us back, we will not hold back,
but we will come to you.

10 For if I am hungry I will cry out to you, God,
and you will give to me.
11 You feed the birds and the fish,
when you send rain in the deserts so that the green grass can spring up,
12 and so prepare fodder in the wilderness for every living creature;
and if they are hungry, they lift their faces to you.
13 You feed kings and rulers and peoples, God,
and what hope has the poor and needy man, if not you, Lord?
14 And you will listen. For who is so kind and gentle but you?
You cheer the humble soul by opening your hand with mercy.
15 A man's kindness is given sparingly, and it is for a day;
and if he repeats it without grumbling, even that is a marvel.
16 But your gift is great, with kindness, and rich,
and the one whose hope is in you will not be held back from your gift.
17 Your mercy is over all the earth, Lord, in kindness.
18 Blessed is the one whom God remembers with a fair measure of sufficiency.
19 If a man has too much, he sins;
20 enough in moderation is sufficient, together with righteousness,
and in that is the Lord's blessing: to have enough, with righteousness.
21 Those who fear the Lord rejoiced in good things,
and your kindness is upon Israel in your kingdom.[a]
22 May the Lord's glory be blessed, for he is our king.

Notes

- a (5:21) Israel ("God strives" or "he who strives with God," Gen 32:28) is the name given to Jacob and then to his descendants.

Chapter 6

Of Solomon: in hope.

1 Happy is the man who is prepared in heart to invoke the Lord's name.
2 When he remembers the name of the Lord, he will be saved;

3 the Lord sets his paths straight,
and the Lord his God keeps the work of his hands safe.
4 Because of the dreams of the night his soul is not troubled;
when he crosses rivers or in storms at sea, he will not be afraid.
5 He gets up from sleep and blesses the name of the Lord;
when his heart is calm, he sings to the name of his God.
6 And he prays to the Lord for his whole house,
and the Lord listens to the prayer of everyone who fears God.
7 Whatever he asks for, he will receive from the Lord;
the Lord will answer every request of a man who is hoping in God.
8 Blessed be the Lord, who shows mercy to those who love him in sincerity.
9 Blessed is the Lord forever.

Chapter 7

Of Solomon: of turning back.

1 Do not take your dwelling far from us, God,
lest those who hate us without cause attack us.
2 For you have rejected them, God;
do not let their feet trample on your holy inheritance.
3 Discipline us yourself, as you wish,
but do not hand us over to the nations.
4 For if you send death, you yourself command it for us;
you will have mercy on us.
5 While your name dwells among us, we will find mercy,

6 and the nation will have no power against us.
7 For you are our protector,
and we will call on you, and you will listen to us.
8 For you will have pity on the house of Israel forever, and you will not reject it.
9 We are under your yoke forever, and under the rod of your discipline.
You will set us straight in the time of your visit.

Notes

- a (7:title) Greek *epistrophēs*; in the Psalms of Solomon the word suggests "repentance" or "being brought back" to God.

Chapter 8

Of Solomon: for victory.

1 The sound of distress and the cry of war has reached my ear,
the sound of a trumpet blaring slaughter and destruction.
2 The noise of a great crowd, like a very strong wind,
like a storm of fire raging through the desert.
3 And I said in my heart, "Where, then, will God judge it?"
4 I heard a sound from Jerusalem, the holy city.
5 My loins were shattered at the news,
my knees gave way;
6 my heart was terrified,
and my bones trembled like flax stalks.
7 I said, "They are making their ways straight in righteousness."
I thought over the judgments of God from the creation of heaven and earth;
I declared God righteous in his judgments of all time.
8 God uncovered their sins in the face of the sun;
the whole earth knew the righteous judgments of God.
9 Their lawless acts were in hidden underground rooms, to provoke him:
10 son with mother and father with daughter were mixed together;
11 each committed adultery with his neighbor's wife;
they made agreements with each other with oaths about these things.
12 They plundered the holy things of God,
as though there were no heir to redeem them.
13 They trampled the altar of the Lord, in every uncleanness,
and with menstrual blood they defiled the sacrifices as if they were common meat.
14 There was no sin they left undone;
they surpassed the nations.

15 For this reason God mixed a spirit of confusion for them,
and made them drink a cup of unmixed wine to drunkenness.
16 He brought one from the end of the earth, one who strikes with power;
17 he decided on war against Jerusalem and its land.
18 The rulers of the land met him with joy,
and said to him, "Your road is blessed;
come, enter in peace."
19 They smoothed the rough roads before his entry;
they opened the gates to Jerusalem;
they crowned her walls.
20 He entered like a father into the house of his sons, in peace;
he set his feet down with great security.
21 He captured her fortified towers and the wall of Jerusalem,
22 and God led him in safety while they went astray.[b]
23 He destroyed their rulers and every wise counselor;
he spilled the blood of Jerusalem's residents as if it were dirty water.
24 He led away their sons and daughters,
whom they had fathered in defilement.
25 They did according to their uncleanness, as their fathers had done.
26 They defiled Jerusalem and the things that were consecrated to God's name.
27 God was shown to be righteous in his judgments among the nations of the earth,
28 and the devout of God were like lambs in their innocence in the midst of them.
29 Praised be the Lord, who judges all the earth in his righteousness.
30 See now, God, you have shown us your judgment in your righteousness;
31 our eyes have seen your judgments, God.
32 We have declared your honored name righteous forever,
for you are the God of righteousness, who judges Israel with discipline.

33 Turn your mercy toward us, God, and have pity on us;
34 bring together Israel's scattered people with compassion and goodness.
35 For your faithfulness is with us,
and though we stiffened our necks, you are our discipliner.
36 Do not overlook us, our God,
lest the nations swallow us up as though there were no one to redeem us.
37 You have been our God from the beginning,
and our hope is in you, Lord.
38 We will not turn away from you,
for your judgments toward us are kind.
39 The favor is ours and our children's forever.
Lord, our savior, we will never be shaken again, for all time.
40 Praised be the Lord in his judgments through the mouth of the devout,
and may Israel be blessed by the Lord forever.

Notes

- a (8:title) The Greek *eis nikos* may stand for Hebrew *lamnatseach* ("for the leader"), a heading found in many biblical psalms, as in Ps 4–6.
- b (8:22) The verses refer to Pompey's entry into Jerusalem in 63 BC, apparently by agreement with one of the rival Hasmonean brothers (Hyrcanus II), followed by the siege and storming of the temple hill by his troops.

Chapter 9

Of Solomon: for reproof.

1 When Israel was led away in exile to a foreign land,
when they had turned away from the Lord who had redeemed them,
2 they were thrown out of the inheritance that the Lord had given them.
Israel is dispersed among every nation, according to the word of God,
3 so that you, God, may be shown to be righteous in your righteousness,
by our lawless acts.

4 For you are a just judge over all the peoples on earth.
5 No one who does wrong can be hidden from your knowledge,
6 and the righteous deeds of your devout are before you, Lord;
and where could a person hide from your knowledge, God?
7 Our deeds are by our own choice and by the authority of our own soul,
to practice justice or injustice in what our hands do.
8 And in your righteousness you visit the sons of men.
9 The one who does righteousness stores up life for himself with the Lord,
and the one who does wrong is himself to blame for the ruin of his soul.
10 For the Lord's judgments are in righteousness, for each man and household.
11 To whom will you be kind, God, if not to those who call on the Lord?
12 He will cleanse a soul from sins in confession, in open acknowledgment,
13 for shame is ours, and on our faces, because of everything.
14 And whose sins will he pardon, if not those of sinners?
15 You will bless the righteous, and will not call them to account for what they have sinned,
and your kindness is for sinners when they repent.
16 And now, you are God, and we are your people, whom you have loved.
Look, and have pity, God of Israel, for we are yours.
17 Do not take your mercy away from us, lest they set upon us.
18 For you chose the descendants of Abraham above all the nations,
and put your name on us, Lord,
and you will not cease forever.[a]
19 You made a covenant with our fathers about us,
and we put our hope in you as our soul turns back.
20 The Lord's mercy is on the house of Israel forever and ever.

Notes

- a (9:18) Abraham ("father of a multitude," Gen 17:5) is named here as the ancestor to whom the covenant promise was first given.

Chapter 10

Among the hymns, of Solomon.

1 How fortunate is the one the Lord keeps in mind by reproving him,
and who is hemmed in from the way of evil by the whip,
to be cleansed from sin, that it may not multiply.
2 The one who prepares his back for the lashes will be cleansed,
for the Lord is kind to those who endure discipline.
3 For he will make the ways of the righteous straight,
and will not bend them in his discipline.
4 The Lord's compassion rests on those who love him sincerely,
and the Lord will not forget his servants but treat them mercifully.
5 For the testimony lies in the Law, an everlasting covenant;
the Lord's testimony oversees what people do with their lives.
6 Our Lord is righteous and devout in his judgments forever,
and Israel will praise the name of the Lord with gladness.
7 And the devout will confess him in the people's gathering,
and God will pity the poor, to the joy of Israel.
8 For God is kind and merciful forever,
and the assemblies of Israel will glorify the name of the Lord.
9 The salvation of the Lord is on the house of Israel, for everlasting gladness.[a]

Notes

- a (10:9) Swete's Greek text reads *sōphrosynē* ("sound mind, self-control"), but editors commonly read *euphrosynē* ("gladness"), as in verses 6 and 7. "Gladness" is used here. This is a point to check against the manuscripts.

Chapter 11

Of Solomon: for expectation.

1 Blow the trumpet in Zion, the trumpet that calls the holy ones.[a]
2 Announce in Jerusalem the voice of the one who brings good news,
for God has had mercy on Israel by visiting them.
3 Stand on a height, Jerusalem, and look at your children,
gathered from east and west, all together, by the Lord.
4 From the north they come with the joy of their God;
from far-off islands God has gathered them.

5 He lowered high mountains to make level ground for them.
6 The hills fled at their coming;
the forests gave them shade as they passed.
7 God made every fragrant tree spring up for them,
so that Israel might pass by with the visit of the glory of their God.
8 Put on, Jerusalem, your garments of glory;
prepare your holy robe,
for God has spoken good things for Israel forever and ever.
9 May the Lord do what he has promised for Israel and Jerusalem;
may the Lord raise Israel up by his glorious name.
The Lord's mercy is on Israel forever and ever.[b]

Notes

- a (11:1) Zion is the hill of Jerusalem on which the temple stood, and in poetry stands for the city itself.
- b (11:9) Compare Baruch 4:36–5:9, which is very close to this psalm; the two probably share a source, or one is based on the other.

Chapter 12

Of Solomon: against the tongue of lawless men.

1 Lord, rescue my soul from the lawless and wicked man,
from the lawless tongue that slanders and speaks falsehood and deceit.
2 The words of a wicked man's tongue twist and turn in many ways.
3 Like a fire in a crowd, it sets fire to its own beauty;
its guest, the tongue, fills houses with lies,
cutting down trees of gladness, setting the lawless ablaze.[a]
4 It throws the houses of the lawless into confusion, with a war of whispering lips.
May God keep the lips of the lawless far away from the innocent, in their helplessness,
and may the bones of the slanderers be scattered far from those who fear the Lord.
5 May the slanderer's tongue perish in a flaming fire, away from the devout.

6 May the Lord guard the soul of the man who makes peace in his house.
7 The salvation of the Lord is on Israel his servant forever,
8 and may the sinners perish from the face of the Lord all at once,
and may the devout of the Lord inherit his promises.

Notes

- a (12:3) The Greek of this verse is rough and the text may be damaged. The sense is that slander is a fire that burns first the speaker and then every household it enters.

Chapter 13

A psalm of Solomon, a comfort for the righteous.

1 The Lord's right hand sheltered me;
his right hand showed us pity.
2 The Lord's arm rescued us from the sword sweeping by,
from hunger and from the sinners' death.
3 Wild beasts rushed upon them, vicious ones;
with their teeth they tore at their flesh,
and with their molars they ground their bones.
And from all these the Lord rescued us.
4 The ungodly man was troubled because of his offenses,
lest he be carried off with the sinners.
5 For the sinner's ruin is terrible,
and none of this will touch the righteous.
6 For the correction of the righteous, done in ignorance,
is not like the ruin of the sinner.
7 The righteous man is disciplined in secret,
so that the sinner will not rejoice over him.
8 For he will admonish the righteous like a dearly loved son,
and his correction is that given to a firstborn.
9 For the Lord will spare his devout ones,
and wipe out their offenses by discipline.
The life of the righteous is forever.
10 But sinners will be taken away to destruction,
and no memory of them will be found any more.

11 The Lord's mercy is on the devout,
and his mercy is on those who fear him.

Chapter 14

A hymn of Solomon.

1 The Lord is faithful to those who love him in truth,
to those who endure his discipline,
to those who walk in righteousness by his commandments,
in the Law that he gave us for our life.
2 The devout of the Lord will live by it forever.
The Lord's paradise, the trees of life, are his devout ones.
3 Their planting is rooted forever;
they will not be uprooted all the days of heaven,
for Israel is the portion and the inheritance of God.
4 Not so the sinners and the lawless,
who loved the day of sharing in their sin;
their desire is in the smallness of decay.[a]
5 And they did not remember God,
for human conduct is always plain to him,
and he knows the secret rooms of the heart before they exist.
6 For this reason their inheritance is Hades and darkness and destruction,
and they will not be found on the day when the righteous receive mercy.
7 But the devout of the Lord will inherit life in gladness.

Notes

- a (14:4) The Greek is difficult. The idea seems to be that the pleasures of the wicked are brief and rotten.

Chapter 15

A psalm of Solomon, with a song.

1 In my distress I called on the Lord,
when I was pressed hard by the sinners, and I was saved.
2 For you are the hope and the refuge of the poor, God.
3 For who is strong, God, if not to give you thanks in truth?

4 And what is a man's power, if not to give thanks to your name?
5 With a new psalm and song, in the gladness of the heart,
lips bearing fruit, with the tongue a well-tuned instrument,
the first offering of lips from a devout and righteous heart—
6 the one who does these things will never be shaken by evil;
the flame of fire and the anger of the unjust will not touch him,
7 when it goes out against sinners from the Lord's presence,
to wipe out all that sinners stand on.
8 For the mark of God is on the righteous, for their salvation;
famine and sword and death are far from the righteous.
9 For they will flee from the devout as from an enemy chasing them,
but they will be pursued and caught, the sinners;
and those who do lawless things will not escape the Lord's judgment,
but will be overtaken as by skilled enemies.
10 For the mark of destruction is on their foreheads.
11 And what sinners inherit is destruction and darkness,
and their lawless acts will chase them down to Hades below.
12 Their inheritance will not be found for their children.
13 For sins will leave the houses of sinners empty.
14 And sinners will perish forever on the day of the Lord's judgment,
when God visits the earth with his judgment.
15 But those who fear the Lord will be shown mercy in it,
and will live by the generosity of their God;
but sinners will perish forever.[a]

Notes

- a (15:15) The "mark" of verses 8 and 10 recalls the sign on the forehead in Ezek 9:4–6, and the mark of the beast in Rev 13:16–17 and 14:9. In the Psalms of Solomon, the righteous bear God's mark for protection and the sinners bear a mark of destruction.

Chapter 16

A hymn of Solomon, for the support of the devout.

1 When my soul was drowsy, away from the Lord,
I almost slipped into the deep sleep of falling.

2 When I was far from God, my soul was almost poured out to death,
near the gates of Hades, with the sinner.
3 When my soul was torn away from the Lord, the God of Israel,
it would have been so, had the Lord not taken hold of me, in his lasting mercy.
4 He pricked me like a horseman's spur, to wake me up;
my savior and helper in every time saved me.
5 I will give thanks to you, God, that you took hold of me for salvation,
and did not count me with the sinners to my ruin.
6 Do not take your mercy away from me, God,
or your remembrance from my heart, until death.
7 Master me, God, away from evil sin
and from every wicked woman who trips up the foolish.
8 And do not let the beauty of a lawless woman deceive me,
nor anyone lying under the power of useless sin.
9 Make straight the works of my hands according to your pattern,
and watch over my steps with your remembrance.
10 Hold in check my tongue and my lips with words of truth;
put anger and unreasoning rage far away from me.
11 Take grumbling and faint-heartedness in distress away from me,
even if I sin when you discipline me to bring me back.
12 But in your good pleasure, with cheerfulness, strengthen my soul;
when you give strength to my soul, what is given will be enough for me.
13 For if you do not give strength, who will endure discipline in poverty?
14 When the soul is poured into the hand of its decay,
your test is in his flesh and in the distress of poverty.
15 If the righteous endures in these things, he will receive mercy from the Lord.

Chapter 17

A psalm of Solomon, with a song, to the king.

1 Lord, you are our king forever and ever,
for in you, God, our soul will boast.

2 And how long is the span of a man's life on earth?
His hope is as long as his time.
3 But we will hope in God our savior,
for the might of our God is forever, with mercy,
4 and our God's kingdom lasts forever, ruling the nations.
5 You, Lord, chose David as king over Israel,
and you swore to him about his descendants forever,
that his kingdom would not fail before you.
6 But because of our sins sinners rose up against us;
they attacked us and drove us out.
Those to whom you made no promise took it by force,
7 and did not glorify your honored name.
They set up a royal house in glory, in place of their height;
8 they laid waste David's throne with the arrogance of a war cry.[b]
9 But you, God, will throw them down and remove their offspring from the earth,
when a man foreign to our race rises up against them.
10 According to their sins you will repay them, God,
so that they find themselves treated as their deeds deserve.
11 God will have no pity on them;
he searched out their offspring and let not one of them go.
12 The Lord is faithful in all his judgments
that he carries out on the earth.
13 The lawless man laid our land waste, taking away its inhabitants;
they destroyed young and old and their children together.
14 In the anger of his splendor he sent them away to the west,
and made the rulers of the land a laughingstock, and showed no pity.
15 In his hostility the enemy acted with arrogance,
and his heart was foreign to our God.
16 And everything he did in Jerusalem was like what the nations do in their cities for their gods.
17 And the sons of the covenant, living among the mixed peoples, gave way to them;

there was no one among them in Jerusalem who practiced mercy and truth.
18 Those who loved the gatherings of the devout fled from them;
like sparrows they were scattered from their nests.
19 They wandered in the deserts to save their souls from evil,
and in the eyes of those who lived abroad a life that had been saved from them was precious.
20 Their dispersion came upon the whole earth, from lawless men.
21 For the heaven held back from letting rain fall on the earth,
and the ever-flowing springs were stopped, from the deeps, from the high mountains,
because there was no one among them who did righteousness and justice;
from their ruler to the least of the people, all were in every sin.
22 The king was in lawlessness, the judge in disobedience, and the people in sin.
23 See, Lord, and raise up for them their king,
the son of David, at the time you have seen, God,
to rule over Israel your servant.[c]
24 Gird him with strength to shatter unjust rulers,
25 to cleanse Jerusalem from the nations who trample her to ruin,
26 in wisdom and righteousness to drive out sinners from the inheritance,
to smash the arrogance of the sinner like a potter's jars;
with an iron rod to break all their strength to pieces,
27 to wipe out lawless nations by a word from his mouth,
so that nations run from his presence when he threatens them,
and to convict sinners by the word of their own hearts.
28 And he will gather a holy people, whom he will lead in righteousness,
and will judge the tribes of the people who have been made holy by the Lord their God.
29 And he will not allow wrong to lodge among them any longer,
and no man who knows evil will live with them.

30 For he will know them, that they are all sons of their God,
and he will divide them up by their tribes on the land.
31 And no foreigner or stranger will live among them anymore.
He will judge peoples and nations with the wisdom of his righteousness. Pause.[d]
32 And he will have the peoples of the nations serve him under his yoke,
and he will glorify the Lord in a place marked out for all the earth to see.
33 And he will cleanse Jerusalem in holiness, as it was from the beginning,
34 so that nations come from the end of the earth to see his glory,
carrying her exhausted sons as presents,
35 and to see the glory of the Lord, with which God has glorified her.
And he is a righteous king, taught by God, over them.
36 There will be no injustice among them in his days,
for all will be holy, and their king will be the Lord's anointed.[e]
37 For he will not put his hope in horse or rider or bow,
nor will he pile up gold or silver for war,
nor will he gather hopes in the numbers of men for the day of war.
38 The Lord himself is his king;
the strong man's hope is the hope he rests in God,
and he will have mercy on all the nations before him in fear.
39 For he will smite the land with a word from his mouth, for all time,
40 he will bless the Lord's people with wisdom and with gladness.
41 And he himself is free from sin, so as to rule a great people,
to convict rulers and remove sinners by the strength of his word.
42 He will not grow weak in his days, because of his God,
for God has made him strong in the holy spirit,
and wise in counsel with understanding, with strength and righteousness.
43 And the Lord's blessing goes with him, with power,
44 and his hope in the Lord will not fail.
And who can stand against him?

He is mighty in what he does and strong through reverence for God;
45 he shepherds the Lord's flock in faith and righteousness,
and will not let any of them grow weak in their pasture.
46 He will lead them all in equality,
and there will be no arrogance among them, so that anyone is oppressed.
47 This is the glory of Israel's king, as God foresaw,
to set him over the house of Israel and train it.
48 His words are refined, more than fine gold, the most precious;
in the assemblies he will judge the tribes of the people made holy.
49 His words are like the words of the holy ones among sanctified peoples.
50 Blessed are those who will live in those days,
to see the good things of Israel in the gathering of the tribes,
which God will do.
51 May God hasten his mercy to Israel;
may he rescue us from the uncleanness of profane enemies.
The Lord himself is our king forever and ever.

Notes

- a (17:title) The Greek *meta ōdēs* ("with a song") is a heading also found on Psalms 15 and 17. "To the king" may refer to the Lord as king, or to the Davidic king expected in the psalm. This psalm is the most important description of the Messiah in the literature of the time.
- b (17:8) The Hasmonean rulers (from 104 BC they took the title "king") were priests, not descendants of David. The psalmist regards them as usurpers.
- c (17:23) "Son of David" is a title here for the future king. The hope of a king from David's line rests on 2 Sam 7:12–16.
- d (17:31) Greek *diapsalma*, as in the Greek Psalms (Hebrew *selah*), a mark whose meaning is not known; it may signal a musical interlude or a pause.
- e (17:36) Greek *christos kyrios*. Most scholars read "the Lord's anointed" (*christos kyriou*, as in 18:6 and 18:8); some think the original was a Hebrew phrase "the Lord's anointed" and that "Lord Messiah" arose in translation, or that a Christian hand altered it. "Anointed" and "Messiah" are the same word (Hebrew *mashiach*, Greek *christos*).

Chapter 18

A psalm of Solomon, still about the Lord's anointed.

1 Lord, your mercy is over the works of your hands forever.
2 Your kindness is on Israel in a rich gift.
Your eyes look on them, and none of them will lack anything.
3 Your ears listen to the prayer of the poor who hope;
your judgments over all the earth are with mercy,
4 and your love is over the descendants of Abraham, the sons of Israel.
Your discipline is on us as on a firstborn, an only son,
5 to turn a listening soul away from foolishness and ignorance.
6 May God cleanse Israel for the day of mercy, with blessing,
for the day of choice, when his anointed one is brought in.
7 Blessed are those who will be born in those days,
to see the good things of the Lord which he will do for the coming generation,
8 under the rod of discipline of the Lord's anointed,
in reverence for his God, in the wisdom of the spirit and of righteousness and strength,
9 to set men straight in works of righteousness in the fear of God,
to set them all before the Lord.
10 A good generation, living in reverence for God, in the days of mercy. Pause.[b]
11 Great is our God and glorious, living on high,
12 who set the lights in their courses to mark the seasons of the hours from day to day,
and they have not left the road you ordered them to follow.
13 In the fear of God their path goes on each day,
from the day God made them and to the end of time.
14 And they have not strayed since the day he made them;
from ancient generations they have not left their ways,
unless God commanded them, through the order given by his servants.

Notes

- a (18:title) Greek *eti peri tou christou kyriou*. As in 17:36 some read “the Lord’s anointed” and others “the Lord Messiah”.
- b (18:10) Greek *diapsalma*; see the note at 17:31.

Psalms 152–155

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

Psalm 152

Spoken by David when he was fighting with a lion and a wolf that were carrying off sheep from his flock.

1 My God, my God, hurry to my side;
support me and set me free,
and deliver my soul from those who kill.[b]
2 Shall I go down to Sheol at the lion's mouth,
or shall the wolf throw me into confusion?[c]
3 Did they not have enough, lurking near my father's sheep
and ripping one away from his fold?
Must they also try to destroy my soul?
4 Have pity, Lord, on your chosen one,
and rescue your devout servant from destruction,
so that he may stand firm in praising you at all times
and give glory to the name of your greatness.[d]
5 Once you have freed him from the grip of the lion that destroys
and the wolf that tears,
and have taken my captive life out of the mouth of the wild beasts,
6 quickly, my Adonai,
send a savior from your presence,
and lift me out of the gaping pit
that wants to shut me up in its depths.[e]

Notes

- a (1:title) Syriac *maryā*, "Lord," is the word the Syriac Bible uses for Yahweh, and it is rendered "Lord" throughout these psalms. In the Mosul manuscript this psalm is preceded by a note saying that these four psalms (152–155) have no explanatory introductions from Eusebius, Athanasius, or Theodore the Interpreter, and are simply written out.
- b (1:1) Syriac *ʾel*, a short form of the divine name "God," appears twice here.

- c (1:2) The Syriac of this verse is run together and uncertain in the manuscript; the sense given is the likeliest, and the last words are read "as reported."
- d (1:4) Another reading, found in some manuscripts, is "so that he may recount your praises at all times."
- e (1:6) Syriac *'adonayhi*, a form of the Hebrew *Adonay*, "my Lord," left in a Hebrew form in the Syriac.

Chapter 2

Psalm 153

Spoken by David when he received God's kindness, when God rescued him from the lion and the wolf and he killed both of them with his own hands.

1 Praise the Lord, all you nations;
  praise him, and bless his name.
2 For he rescued the soul of his chosen one from the hands of death,
  and saved his devout servant from destruction.
3 He delivered me from the snares of Sheol,
  and drew my soul out of the pit that cannot be fathomed.
4 For just before my rescue came out from his presence,
  I had become two portions for two beasts.[a]
5 But he sent his angel,
  shut up the gaping mouths against me,
  and saved my life from destruction.
6 My soul praises him and exalts him
  for all his kindnesses,
  which he has done and will do for me.

Notes

- a (2:4) Literally "two portions for two beasts." The idea is that each animal had a share of him, as though he were already divided between them.

Chapter 3

Psalm 154

The prayer of Hezekiah when the Assyrians were surrounding him and he was asking God for relief from them, like a people who had obtained leave from Cyrus to go back to their own place and who ask God that their hope be fulfilled.

1 With a loud voice praise God;
in the assembly of the many, make his glory heard.
2 Among the throng of the upright, praise him;
with the righteous, recount his majesty.
3 Unite your soul with the good and the whole-hearted,
so as to praise the Most High.
4 Gather together to make known his strength;
do not be slow to show his deliverance,
and his glory to all the simple.[b]
5 So that the Lord's honor may be known, wisdom was given.[c]
6 So that his works may be recounted, she was made known to people.[d]
7 She was given to make his strength known to the simple,
and to make those who lack heart understand his glory,
8 who are far from her entrances
and far away from her gates.
9 For the Most High is the Lord of Jacob,
and his splendor is over all his works.
10 And the person who praises the Most High,
he will take pleasure in him,
like one who offers fine flour,
11 and like one who offers he-goats and young bulls,
and like one who makes the altar shine with a great number of burnt offerings,
and like the fragrance of spices from the hand of the righteous.[e]
12 From the gates of the upright his voice is heard,
and out of the upright's own voice comes his meditation.[f]
13 At their meal there is plenty, in truth,
and at their drink they drink together.
14 Their conversation dwells on the Most High's Law,
and they speak in order to declare his strength.
15 How far from the wicked is speaking of him,
and from all the unjust, knowing him!
16 See, the Lord's eye looks with pity on the good,

17 and on those who praise him he will multiply mercies,
and from the time of evil he will rescue their souls.
18 Blessed be the Lord, who rescued the afflicted from the hand of foreigners,
and delivered the blameless from the hand of the wicked,
19 who raises up a strong horn from Jacob,
a judge for the nations from Israel,
20 that he may make his dwelling long in Zion,
and that it may be planted in Jerusalem for all ages.[g]

Notes

- a (3:title) Hezekiah, king of Judah about 715–686 BC, was besieged by the Assyrian king Sennacherib in 701 BC (2 Kings 18–19; Isaiah 36–37). The name means "Yahweh strengthens." Cyrus the Persian allowed the exiles to return in 538 BC (Ezra 1). The heading joins the two situations and does not fit the psalm well; in other Syriac manuscripts, the Hezekiah heading belongs to Psalm 154 and the Cyrus heading to Psalm 155, as reported.
- b (3:4) The Syriac word is uncertain; it means something like "the simple" or "the untaught." Wright's 1887 English has "babes." The same word is used in verse 7.
- c (3:5) In the Hebrew text from Qumran (11QPs-a, as reported), wisdom is a woman and is called "she" and "her" through verse 8; the Syriac pronouns are less clear. "Her" in verse 8 follows the likely sense.
- d (3:6) In the Hebrew text from Qumran (as reported), wisdom is a woman, and she is addressed as "she" and "her" through the rest of the psalm. The Syriac pronouns are not always clear, so "her" in verse 8 follows the likely sense.
- e (3:11) Syriac *bsāmē*, "spices." Wright's 1887 text, from a later family of manuscripts, has "incense."
- f (3:12) Syriac *martīnūteh*. The word is uncertain and could also mean "his murmured prayer." Wright has "admonition." Whose voice is meant is also unclear.
- g (3:20) Some manuscripts read "and may beautify our age in Jerusalem," a different line.

Chapter 4

Psalm 155

The prayer of Hezekiah when the Assyrians were surrounding him, and he asked God for relief from them.

1 Lord, I called to you; hear me.
2 I spread out my hands toward the dwelling places of your holiness.
3 Bend your ear to me and grant me my request.

4 Do not hold back my petition from me.
5 Build up my soul,
and do not tear it down.
6 Do not lay it bare before the wicked.
7 Turn away from me those who repay evil,
O judge of truth.[a]
8 Lord, do not judge me according to my sins,
for no one living is righteous before you.
9 Make me wise, Lord, in your Law,
and teach me your judgments.[b]
10 So that many may hear of your works,
and the nations may confess your glory.[c]
11 Remember me and do not forget me,
and do not bring me into what is too hard for me.
12 Pass away from me the sins of my youth,
and do not remember my rebellion against me.
13 Cleanse me, Lord, from the evil scab,
and let it not return to me again.
14 Dry up its roots from me,
and do not let its leaves sprout in me.
15 Mighty and great are you, Lord;
therefore my petition is granted before you.
16 To whom shall I appeal, so that he may give to me?
And what more can human might supply?
17 From before you, Lord, comes my confidence.
I called to the Lord, and he answered me,
and healed the break in my heart.
18 I dozed and fell asleep;
I dreamed, and then was woken.[d]
19 You held me up, Lord,
and I accept it, because the Lord has delivered me.[e]
20 Now I will look on their shame.
I put my hope in you and was not put to shame.
Give honor forever and ever.

21 Redeem Israel, your chosen,
and the house of Jacob, your tested one.[f]

Notes

- a (4:7) Syriac *dīnā d-qushtā*, “judge of truth.” The first words, *parʿay bīshtā*, “repayers of evil,” are not entirely certain.
- b (4:9) The manuscript has a damaged letter at the end of this line, and the Syriac text printed by its editors marks the end of the verse as uncertain.
- c (4:10) Syriac *ʿabdayk*. The consonants can be read as “your works” or “your servants.” “Works” is followed because the line is about what is heard and fits the parallel clause about confessing his glory.
- d (4:18) Another reading is “I was helped.”
- e (4:19) Syriac *ʾeqbal*, “I receive” or “I accept.” This is an uncertain readingWright’s 1887 English has “I will return thanks,” which may reflect a different reading.
- f (4:21) At this point the Mosul manuscript closes the Psalter with a note: “Finished, with the help of our Lord: the book of the Psalms of the blessed David, prophet and king, together with five psalms that are not in the Greek reckoning or the Hebrew. But, as people say, they were found in Syriac, and I wrote them for those who look for them.”

Odes of Solomon

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

Ode 1

1 The Lord is on my head as a crown, and I will never be left without
him.[a]

2 A crown of truth was woven for me,
and it made your branches sprout in me.

3 For it is not like a withered crown that puts out no buds;

4 but you are alive on my head,
and you have blossomed on me.

5 Your fruit is ripe and whole,
brimming with your salvation.

Notes

- a (1:1) Ode 1 is not in the Syriac manuscripts, which have lost their opening pages. It survives in Coptic, quoted in the *Pistis Sophia* (3rd–4th century AD), where it is called the nineteenth ode of Solomon. The English here is translated from the Coptic "as reported" in the English translation of J. R. Harris and A. Mingana (1920), checked against the Syriac idiom of the other odes; no Coptic manuscript was read directly.

Chapter 2

Ode 2

1 [This ode is lost.][a]

Notes

- a (2:1) Both the Syriac manuscripts break off before Ode 3, so Ode 2 has not survived in Syriac, and no Coptic quotation of it is known. Some scholars think that a few lines of the Greek text of Ode 11 in Papyrus Bodmer XI (verse 16, and a line after verse 22) that are not in the Syriac may be borrowed from this lost ode (as reported); they are given in a note at Ode 11.

Chapter 3

Ode 3

1 [I put on the love of the Lord.][a]
2 And his limbs are with him, and I hang upon them,
and he loves me.[b]
3 I could never have learned to love the Lord,
unless he had first loved me.
4 Who can tell what love is,
except the one who is loved?
5 I love the Beloved, and my own soul loves him;
and wherever his rest is, I am there too.
6 And I will be no stranger,
for with the Lord, the Most High and Merciful, there is no grudging.
7 I have been mingled with him, for the lover has found the beloved;
and because I love the Son, I will become a son.
8 For whoever joins himself to the one who does not die
will himself become undying;
9 and whoever delights in the Living One
will become living.
10 This is the spirit of the Lord, which does not lie,
which teaches people to know his ways.
11 Be wise, and understanding, and watchful. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (3:1) The first words of this ode are lost in the manuscript; the Syriac that is left reads "… I put on." The words in square brackets are supplied from the sense of the next lines, as in the first edition by Harris and Mingana.
- b (3:2) The Syriac says "with him." Some editors change it to "with me."

Chapter 4

Ode 4

1 No one, my God, can change your holy place;
no one can alter it and set it in another place,
2 because they have no authority over it.
For you planned your sanctuary before you made the other places.
3 What is older will not be changed by what is lesser than itself.
You have given your heart, Lord, to those who are faithful to you.

4 You will never be idle,
and you will never be without fruit.
5 For one hour of faithfulness to you
is worth more than all days and years.
6 For who could put on your goodness
and be wronged?[a]
7 For your seal is known,
and your creatures are acquainted with it.[b]
8 Your hosts take hold of it,
and the great and chosen angels are clothed with it.
9 You have given us your partnership.
It was not that you were lacking anything from us;
it was we who were lacking you.
10 Pour out your drops upon us,
and open your rich springs, which pour out milk and honey for us.
11 For there is no changing of mind in you,
so that you would change your mind about anything you have promised.
12 And the end was plain to you.
13 What you gave you gave as a free gift,
so that you would never go back and take it again.
14 For everything was plain to you, as God,
and was set in order from the beginning in front of you.
15 And you, Lord, made all things. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (4:6) The Syriac verb means "be wronged" or "be treated unjustly"; some translators render it "be condemned."
- b (4:7) The Syriac can mean "know it" or "are known to it." A letter of the word "known" is damaged in the manuscript.

Chapter 5

Ode 5

1 I give you thanks,
Lord, for I love you.

2 Most High, do not abandon me,
for you are my hope.
3 Freely I have received your goodness;
by it I will live.
4 Let my persecutors come and not see me.
5 Let a cloud of gloom fall over their eyes,
and a haze of darkness make them black.
6 And let there be no light for them to see,
so that they cannot seize me.
7 Let their plan be dulled,
and let what they have schemed come back on their own heads.[a]
8 For they planned a plan,
and it did not come about for them.
9 They made themselves ready for evil,
and were found empty.
10 My hope is in the Lord,
so I will not fear.
11 And because the Lord is my deliverer,
I will not be afraid.
12 He is a crown on my head,
and I will not be shaken.
13 And if everything is shaken,
I stand.
14 And if everything that is seen perishes,
I will not die.
15 The Lord is with me,
and I with him. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (5:7) The Syriac word used for "dulled" is *ʿubāyē*, which normally means "thick" or "heavy"; it is unclear in this place. Some editors emend it to "weak." The Coptic form of this ode, in the *Pistis Sophia*, reads "powerless," as reported.

Chapter 6

Ode 6

1 As the wind moves over the harp,
and the strings speak,
2 so the Spirit of the Lord speaks in my limbs,
and I speak by his love.
3 For he destroys everything that is foreign,
and everything belongs to the Lord.
4 For so it was from the beginning,
and so it will be to the end,
5 so that nothing may be against him,
and nothing stand up to oppose him.
6 The Lord has made the knowledge of himself greater,
and he is eager that those things be known which have been given to us through his goodness.
7 And he has given us his praise for the sake of his name;
our spirits praise his Holy Spirit.
8 For a stream went out and became a great and wide river;
it swept away everything, broke it up,
and brought it to the Temple.[a]
9 And the dam-builders among people could not hold it back,
nor could the skill of those who hold back waters.
10 For it came over the face of the whole earth,
and filled everything.
11 And all the thirsty on the earth drank,
and thirst was loosened and put out;
12 for the drink was given from the Most High.
13 Blessed, then, are the servants of that drink,
those to whom his water has been entrusted.
14 They have refreshed dry lips,
and raised up the will that had gone slack.
15 And souls that were about to leave,
they seized from death.
16 They set limbs that had collapsed straight
and upright again.

17 They put strength into their coming,
and light into their eyes.
18 Everyone recognized them as the Lord's,
and they lived by the living water that lasts for ever. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (6:8) "Temple" here is the Syriac word *haykla*. The Coptic version of this ode (in the *Pistis Sophia*) has a different sentence for this verse, as reported.

Chapter 7

Ode 7

1 As anger rushes at wrongdoing,
so joy rushes to the beloved,
and brings in its fruits without holding back.[a]
2 My joy is the Lord, and my running is toward him;
this is my beautiful way.
3 For I have the Lord as my helper.
He made himself known to me freely, in his simplicity, because his kindness made his greatness small.
4 He became like me, so that I could take him in;
he was counted like me in his appearance, so that I could put him on.
5 I did not tremble at the sight of him,
because he was gracious to me.
6 He became like my nature, so that I could learn him;
like my form, so that I would not turn away from him.
7 The Father of knowledge
is the Word of knowledge.
8 He who created wisdom
is wiser than his works.
9 And he who made me before I was
knew what I would do when I came to be.
10 So he was gracious to me in his great graciousness,
and gave me to ask of him,
and to receive from his sacrifice.

11 For he is the one who does not decay,
the fullness of the ages and their Father.
12 He let himself be seen by his own,
so that they might know their maker,
and not imagine that they came from themselves.
13 For he set his path toward knowledge;
he made it wide and made it long,
and brought it to complete fullness.
14 And he set the footprints of his light upon it,
and it went on from the beginning to the end.
15 For through him it was served,
and it rested in the Son.
16 And by his salvation he will lay hold of everything,
and the Most High will be made known among his holy ones,
17 to carry word to those who have songs about the Lord's coming,
so that they may go out to meet him,
singing to him with joy and with a harp of many voices.
18 The seers will go before him,
and will be seen before him.
19 They will praise the Lord for his love,
because he is near, and he sees.
20 And hatred will be lifted from the earth,
and will be drowned together with jealousy.
21 Ignorance has been destroyed,
now that the knowledge of the Lord has come.
22 Those who sing will sing of the goodness of the Lord, the Most High,
and bring their psalms.
23 Their heart will be bright as day,
and their sweet voices will match the greatness of the Lord's majesty.
24 And nothing will be without life,
or without knowledge, or without speech.

25 He gave his creation a mouth,
to open the voice of the mouth toward him
and praise him.
26 Declare his power,
and show his goodness. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (7:1) The Syriac reads "anger" (*ḥemtā*) and "wrongdoing" (*ʿawlūtā*). Several scholars change these words to "love" and "infancy" or "childhood," because the first half of the comparison then matches the second. The Syriac is translated as it stands.

Chapter 8

Ode 8

1 Open, open your hearts to the rejoicing of the Lord,
and let your love flow from the heart to the lips,
2 to bring the Lord fruit, a holy life,
and to speak watchfully in his light.
3 Rise and stand upright,
you who were once bowed down.
4 You who have been silent, speak,
for your mouth is now opened.
5 You who were despised, be lifted up,
for your righteousness has been lifted up.[a]
6 The Lord's right hand is with you,
and he will help you.
7 And peace was made ready for you
before your war ever took place.
8 Listen to the word of truth,
and take in the knowledge of the Most High.
9 Your flesh does not understand what I am telling you,
nor your clothing what I am showing you.
10 Guard my secret,
you who are guarded by it.
11 Guard my faith, you who are guarded by it.

12 And understand my knowledge,
you who know me in truth.
13 Love me with love, you who love.
14 For I do not turn my face away from my own,
because I know them.
15 And before they came to be, I knew them,
and I sealed their faces.[b]
16 I formed their limbs;
my own breasts I made ready for them,
so that they could drink my holy milk, and live on it.
17 I delighted in them,
and I do not blush for them.
18 For they are my work,
and the power of my thoughts.
19 Who then will stand against my work,
or who will not be subject to them?
20 I wanted them, and made mind and heart; and they are mine;
and at my right hand I set my chosen ones.
21 My righteousness goes ahead of them,
and they will not be cut off from my name,
since it is with them.
22 Ask, and increase, and stay in the love of the Lord,
beloved ones in the Beloved,
the ones guarded in the Living One,
and the redeemed in the one who was redeemed.
23 And you will be found incorruptible in all the ages,
for the name of your Father. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (8:5) The Digital Syriac Corpus transcription marks a gap here. The verse is given as in Harris and Mingana (1916–1920), "as reported."
- b (8:15) The numbering of the second half of this ode differs between editions. Harris and Mingana number this part 11 to 14 and end the ode at verse 14; this book uses the 23-verse numbering of the Digital Syriac Corpus.

Chapter 9

Ode 9

1 Open your ears,
and I will speak to you.
2 Give me your soul,
so that I may give you my soul too.
3 The word of the Lord and what he desires
is a holy thought that he thought concerning his Messiah.
4 For your lives are by the will of the Lord,
and his purpose is life for ever,
and your completion is without decay.
5 Be enriched in God the Father,
and receive the purpose of the Most High.
Be made strong and be redeemed by his goodness.
6 For I announce peace to you, his holy ones,
so that none who hear will fall in battle,
7 and so that those who have come to know him will not perish,
and those who accept him will not be put to shame.
8 Truth is an everlasting crown;
blessed are those who place it on their heads.
9 It is a precious stone,
for there have been wars over the crown.
10 And Righteousness took it,
and gave it to you.[a]
11 Put on the crown through the true covenant of the Lord,
and all who have conquered will be written in his book.
12 For their writing is the victory that is yours;
and she sees you before her,
and wants you to be redeemed. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (9:10) The Syriac reads *zadiqūtā*, "Righteousness." Some scholars read *zākūtā*, "Victory," which suits verses 11–12, where the same word appears for the victory the readers have won.

Chapter 10

Ode 10

1 The Lord shaped my mouth by his word,
and opened my heart by his light.
2 And he made his deathless life dwell in me,
and let me speak the fruit of his peace,
3 to turn back the souls of those who want to come to him,
and to take a good captivity captive, for freedom.
4 I was made strong and mighty, and I took the world captive;
and this became for me a praise of the Most High, and of God my Father.
5 And the nations that were scattered were gathered together;
and I was not made unclean by my sins,[a]
because they praised me in the high places.
6 And the footprints of light were set upon their heart,
and they walked in my life and were redeemed,
and became my people for ever and ever. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (10:5) The Syriac word *ḥawbay* can mean "my sins," "my debts," or "what I owe."

Chapter 11

Ode 11

1 My heart was circumcised, and its blossom appeared;
and goodness sprang up in it,
and it bore fruit for the Lord.
2 For the Most High circumcised me with his Holy Spirit.
He uncovered my inmost being to himself,
and filled me with his love.
3 His circumcision of me became my redemption.
I ran on the road, in his peace, the road of truth,
4 from the beginning to the end,
and I received his knowledge.
5 And I was set firm on the rock of truth,
where he himself had stood me up.

6 And speaking waters came near my lips from the Lord's spring,
which has no envy.
7 So I drank
and was drunk with the living water that does not die.
8 Yet my drunkenness was not the drunkenness of ignorance,
for I left behind what is empty
9 and turned to the Most High, my God,
and was made rich by his gift.
10 I abandoned the folly that is scattered over the earth;
I stripped it off and threw it away from me.
11 And the Lord renewed me with his own clothing,
and took me as his own with his light.
12 From above he gave me rest that cannot decay,
and I became like a land that blossoms and rejoices in its fruit.
13 And the Lord was like the sun shining on the face of the land.
14 My eyes were lit,
and my face received the dew.
15 My breath was sweetened by the pleasant fragrance of the Lord.
16 And he took me into his paradise,
where the Lord's pleasure is richly stored.[a]
17 And I bowed down to the Lord because of his glory,
18 and I said: Blessed are those,
Lord, who are planted in your land,
and have their place in your paradise,
19 and who grow with the growth of your trees,
and have passed from darkness into light.
20 … Look, all your workers are good, doing good works,
(and turning from wickedness to your sweetness.)[b]
21 (And they turned the bitterness of the trees away from them,
when they were planted in your land.)
22 … and the everlasting memorial of your faithful servants.[c]
23 For the place of your paradise is wide,
and nothing in it is idle,
but everything is full of fruit.

24 Glory to you, God, for the endless delight of paradise. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (11:16) The Greek text of this ode (Papyrus Bodmer XI), as reported, has here six further lines that the Syriac does not have: "I saw trees, flourishing and full of fruit; their crown grew of itself; their wood blossomed and their fruits laughed. Their roots were from deathless ground, and a river of gladness watered them all around, in the land of everlasting life." They are given here as reported and are not part of the Syriac text translated in this book.
- b (11:20) In the Syriac, verses 20 to 22 are damaged. The Digital Syriac Corpus marks gaps with "…" at the start of verses 20 and 22 and puts all of verse 21 and part of verse 20 in round brackets, which signals that these words are supplied or uncertain. They are translated here as they stand, with the gaps shown as "…" and the bracketed words in round brackets.
- c (11:22) As reported, the Greek of this ode has a longer text here and a blessing on "those who see your waters". The Syriac, as far as it survives, has the shorter form translated here.

Chapter 12

Ode 12

1 He filled me with words of truth,
so that I could speak them.
2 As water flows, truth flowed from my mouth,
and my lips revealed its fruit.
3 He caused his knowledge to overflow in me,
because the Lord's mouth is the true Word,
and the doorway of his light.
4 The Most High gave it to his worlds, who are the interpreters of his beauty,
the tellers of his glory,
the confessors of his thought,
the heralds of his mind,
and the teachers of his works.
5 For the swiftness of the Word cannot be told,
and as it is said, so are its speed
and its sharpness; its course has no limit.
6 It never fails but stands firm,
and it does not know descent or the way down.[a]

7 For as its work is, so is its aim;
for it is light and the dawning of thought.
8 Through it the worlds speak to one another,
and those who were silent gained speech.
9 Love and harmony came from it,
and they told one another what they had.
10 They were stirred by the Word
and knew the one who made them,
because they were in harmony.
11 The mouth of the Most High addressed them,
and his explanation ran swiftly through it.
12 For the dwelling place of the Word is the son of man,
and its truth is love.[b]
13 Blessed are those who have understood everything through it,
and have known the Lord in his truth. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (12:6) Syriac *peṯgāmā*, "word, utterance", is the same word used for "Word" in Ode 7:7. It is not the Greek *Logos* of John 1.
- b (12:12) Syriac *bar nāšā*, "son of man", can mean simply "a human being".

Chapter 13

Ode 13

1 See, the Lord is our mirror. Open your eyes,
and look at yourselves in him,
2 and learn what your faces are like,
and speak praises to his spirit.
3 Wipe the paint off your faces,[a]
love his holiness and put it on.
4 Then you will be without blemish before him at all times. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (13:3) The Syriac word *ṣīdātā* is rare, and its sense is uncertain. "Paint" is a likely guess, since the verse is about faces.

Chapter 14

Ode 14

1 As a son's eyes are on his father,
so my eyes, Lord, are on you at all times.
2 For with you are my breasts and my nourishment.[a]
3 Do not turn your mercies away from me,
Lord, and do not take your kindness from me.
4 Stretch out your right hand to me at all times,
and be my guide to the end, as you please.
5 Let me be pleasing before you for your glory, and
for your name's sake let me be rescued from evil.
6 May your gentleness, Lord, stay with me,
and the fruits of your love.
7 Teach me the psalms of your truth,
so that I may bear fruit in you.
8 Open for me the harp of your Holy Spirit,
that I may praise you, Lord, with every note of it.
9 And as great as your mercies are,
so give to me, and hurry to grant what we ask.
10 You are able to supply all our needs. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (14:2) Literally "my breasts", the image of a nursing mother, together with the word for refreshment or sustenance.

Chapter 15

Ode 15

1 As the sun is a joy to those who look
for its day, so the Lord is my joy.
2 He is my sun;
his rays have lifted me up,
and his light has driven all darkness from my face.
3 In him I gained eyes,
and I saw his holy day.
4 Ears were given to me,
and I heard his truth.
5 The thought of knowledge came to me,
and I was refreshed in him.

6 I left the way of error and went to him,
and I received salvation from him without grudging.
7 He gave to me as his own gift,
and he made me as his great beauty.
8 I put on incorruption by his name,
and took off corruption by his kindness.
9 Death was destroyed before my face,
and Sheol was ended by my word.
10 And deathless life rose in the Lord's land,
and was made known to his faithful,
and was given without limit to all who trust in him. Hallelujah.

Chapter 16

Ode 16

1 As the farmer's work is the plow,
and the helmsman's work is steering the ship,
so the psalm of the Lord, in his praises, is my work.
2 My craft and my service are in his praises,
for his love has fed my heart,
and his fruits have gushed up to my lips.
3 The Lord is my love,
and so I will sing to him.
4 For I am strong in praising him,
and I have faith in him.
5 I will open my mouth,
and his Spirit will speak within me the Lord's glory
and his beauty,
6 the deed of his hands
and the toil of his fingers,
7 the greatness of his mercies
and the strength of his word.
8 For the word of the Lord searches out what is not seen,
and examines his thought.[a]
9 The eye sees what he has made,
and the ear hears his thought.

10 He spread out the earth
and set the waters in the sea.
11 He stretched out the heavens
and fixed the stars.
12 He established the creation and set it up,
and then rested from his works.
13 Created things run their courses
and do their work,
and they do not know how to stand still or be idle.
14 And the heavenly hosts are subject to his word.
15 The treasury of light is the sun,
and the treasury of darkness is the night.
16 He made the sun for the day, to make it bright;
but night brings darkness across the surface of the earth.
17 Their turns, one after the other,
declare the beauty of God.
18 And nothing exists apart from the Lord,
for he was before anything came to be.
19 The worlds came into being through his word,
and through the thought of his heart.
20 Praise and honor to his name. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (16:8) The meaning of the second half is disputed, since it is not clear whose "thought" is meant.

Chapter 17

Ode 17

1 My God crowned me,
and my crown is alive.
2 I was made righteous by my Lord,
and my salvation does not decay.
3 I was set free from empty things,
and I am not condemned.

4 My bonds were cut by her hands.[a] I took the face
and shape of a new person,
and walked in it, and was redeemed.
5 And the thought of truth led me,
and I followed it and did not stray.
6 All who saw me were amazed,
and to them I seemed a stranger.
7 And he who knew me and raised me is the Most High,
in all his fullness.[b]
8 He glorified me by his kindness,
and lifted my knowledge to the height of truth.
9 There he gave me the path of his footsteps,
and I opened doors that were shut,
10 and broke the iron bars in pieces;
but my own iron grew hot and melted before me.
11 Nothing seemed shut against me,
since I was the door for all things.
12 I went to all my captives to free them,
so that I would leave no one bound, and none to bind.
13 And I gave my knowledge without grudging,
and my request in my love.
14 I sowed my fruits in hearts,
and changed them into myself.
15 They received my blessing and lived;
they gathered to me and were redeemed.
16 For they became my limbs,
and I was their head.
17 Praise to you, our head, Lord Messiah. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (17:4) The Syriac has "her hands"; the feminine word has no clear antecedent in the surviving text.
- b (17:7) The Digital Syriac Corpus numbers this ode in 17 verses and gives Harris and Mingana's numbering, one lower from here on, in brackets. This book follows the 17-verse numbering.

Chapter 18

Ode 18

1 My heart was raised up by the love of the Most High,
and grew wide, so that I might praise him for his name.
2 My limbs were strengthened
so that they would not fall from his power.
3 Sicknesses drew away from my body,
and it stood before the Lord by his will,
for his kingdom is sure.
4 Lord, because of those who are lacking,
do not take your word from me.
5 And do not, because of their works,
hold back your perfection from me.
6 Do not let light be overcome by darkness,
or truth flee from falsehood.
7 Let your right hand set up victory
for our salvation. Receive us from every place,
and guard everyone who is held fast by evils.[a]
8 You are my God. Falsehood
and death are not in your mouth; perfection is your will.
9 You do not know emptiness,
because it does not know you either.
10 You do not know error,
because it does not know you either.
11 And ignorance appeared like dust,
and like the foam of the sea.
12 The empty-minded thought it great,
and they too became like it, and were emptied.
13 But those who knew, and who thought it through,
knew, and were not defiled by their thoughts.
14 They were in the Most High's mind,
and they laughed at those who walk in error.
15 These spoke truth,
out of the breath the Most High had breathed into them.

16 Praise and great majesty to his name. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (18:7) The sense of this verse is uncertain in the Syriac.

Chapter 19

Ode 19

1 I was offered a cup of milk,
and I drank it in the sweet kindness of the Lord.
2 The Son is the cup, and the one who was milked is the Father,
and the Holy Spirit milked him,
3 because his breasts were full,
and it was not right that his milk be poured out for nothing.
4 The Holy Spirit opened her womb,
and mixed the milk from the Father's two breasts,[a]
5 and gave the mixture to the world,
though they did not know it. And those who take it in its fullness are on the right hand.
6 (The womb of the virgin took it,
and she conceived and gave birth.
7 And the virgin became a mother with many mercies.)[b]
8 She was in labor and bore a son, and had no pain,
because it did not happen without purpose.
9 And she did not need a midwife,
because he delivered her.
10 She gave birth like a man,
by her own will; she gave birth openly,
and took firm possession of him with a great hold.
11 She loved him in redemption,
and guarded him in kindness,
and showed him in majesty. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (19:4) In Syriac the word for "Spirit", *rūḥā*, can be feminine, which is why the Spirit is "her" here.
- b (19:7) Verses 6 and 7 are in round brackets in the Digital Syriac Corpus, which marks words that are damaged or supplied.

Chapter 20

Ode 20

1 I am a priest of the Lord,
and I serve him as a priest.
2 And I offer to him the sacrifice of his own thought.
3 For his thought is not like the world,
nor like the flesh, nor like those who serve in the way of the flesh.
4 The sacrifice of the Lord is righteousness,
and a pure heart and pure lips.
5 Offer your inmost parts without blemish. Let your affections not press upon affections,
and let your own self not press upon another self.
6 Do not buy a stranger with the blood of your own life,[a]
and do not strip him of the covering of his shame.
7 But put on the Lord's kindness,
without grudging, and come to his paradise,
and make yourself a crown from his tree.
8 Put it on your head and be glad,
and lean on his rest.
9 His glory will go ahead of you,
and you will receive from his kindness and goodness,
and be anointed with truth in the glory of his holiness.
10 Praise and honor to his name. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (20:6) The Digital Syriac Corpus shows that a line is missing here. Other editions supply a line about not cheating a neighbor, which is given here only "as reported" and is not translated.

Chapter 21

Ode 21

1 I lifted up my arms to the height,
to the mercy of the Lord,
2 because he had thrown my bonds off me,
and my helper lifted me up to his mercy and to his salvation.

3 I put off darkness
and put on light.
4 And I gained limbs besides my soul,
and there was no sickness or affliction or suffering in them.
5 And above all the thought of the Lord was a help to me,
and his fellowship, which does not decay.
6 I was lifted up into the light,
and I passed before his face.
7 I kept near him, praising and confessing him. …
8 My heart overflowed and appeared in my mouth,
and rose upon my lips.
9 And the gladness of the Lord and his praise grew on my face. Hallelujah.

Chapter 22

Ode 22

1 He who brought me down from on high,
and brought me up from the regions below,
2 who gathers what is in the middle
and throws them to me,
3 who scattered my enemies
and my opponents,
4 who gave me power over bonds,
to loose them,
5 who with my hands struck down the seven-headed dragon,
and set me over its roots to destroy its seed.
6 You were there to help me,
and everywhere your name was around me.
7 Your right hand destroyed (the poison of evil),
and your hand made the way smooth for those who trust in you.
8 (You chose them) from the graves,
(and you separated them) from the dead.
9 You took dead bones
and covered them with bodies.

10 They were motionless,
and you gave the power to work to the living.
11 Your way was without decay,
and so was your face. You brought your world to incorruption,
so that everything might be dissolved and made new,
12 and that your rock might be the foundation of everything. Upon it you built your kingdom,
and it became the dwelling place of the holy ones. Hallelujah.

Chapter 23

Ode 23

1 Joy is for the holy ones,
and who can put it on but they alone?
2 Grace belongs to the chosen,
and who will receive it except those who have trusted in it from the beginning?
3 Love belongs to the chosen,
and who will put it on except those who have owned it from the beginning?
4 Walk in the knowledge of the Most High,
and you will know the Lord's kindness without grudging,
and for his gladness, and for the perfection of his knowledge.
5 His thought was like a letter,
and his will came down from the height,
6 and it was sent like an arrow shot from a bow with force.
7 And many hands rushed to the letter,
to snatch it and take it and read it.
8 But it escaped from their fingers,
and they were afraid of it and of the seal on it,
9 because they were not allowed to break its seal,
for the power over the seal was greater than they.
10 But those who saw it went after the letter,
to know where it would land,
and who would read it,
and who would hear it.

11 But a wheel received it,
and it came upon the wheel.
12 And with it was a sign of kingship
and of government.
13 And everything that disturbed the wheel it mowed down
and cut off.
14 It gathered a crowd of adversaries,
and spanned rivers,
and uprooted many forests,
15 and made a broad road.
16 The head came down to the feet,
because the wheel ran as far as the feet,
and whatever had come upon it.
17 The letter was a command,
because all the places were gathered together.
18 And a head was seen, the head that was revealed,
the Son of truth from the Father, the Most High.
19 And he inherited everything
and took it. And the plan of the many was brought to an end.
20 Then all the rebels grew hot and fled,
and those who persecuted and hated were put out.
21 And the letter was a great tablet,
written completely by the finger of God.
22 The name of the Father was upon it,
and also of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
to reign for ever and ever. Hallelujah.

Chapter 24

Ode 24

1 The dove fluttered over the head of our Lord Messiah,
because he was her head.
2 She sang over him,
and her voice could be heard.
3 The inhabitants were afraid,
and the settlers were shaken.

4 The bird gave up its wings,
and every creeping thing died in its hole.
5 The depths were opened and covered again,
and they cried to the Lord like women in labor.
6 And no food was given to them,
because it was not theirs.
7 And the depths sank in the Lord's sinking,[a]
and they perished in the thought they had held from the beginning.
8 For they had been corrupt from the beginning,
and the end of their corruption was life.
9 And everything about them that was lacking perished,
because they had no word to speak so that they might live.
10 And the Lord destroyed the thoughts of all those who had no truth.
11 For those who were lifted up in their hearts lacked wisdom,
and so were rejected, because truth was not with them.
12 And they were removed,
because truth was not with them.
13 For the Lord revealed his way
and spread out his kindness,
14 and those who recognized it know his holiness. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (24:7) The Syriac uses the same root twice, "sank" and "sinking", and the word can also mean "sealing". The sense of the verse is uncertain.

Chapter 25

Ode 25

1 I was set free from my bonds,
and I ran to you, my God.
2 (For you were the right hand of salvation)
and my helper.
3 You held back those who stood against me,
and (they were not seen again).
4 For your face was with me,
and it saved me by your kindness.

5 But in the eyes of many I was despised
and rejected, and in their sight I was like lead.
6 And strength came to me from you,
and help.
7 You set a lamp for me on my right and on my left,
so that nothing in me would be without light.
8 I was covered with the cover of your Spirit,
and I took off the garments of skin.
9 For your right hand lifted me up
and took sickness away from me.
10 I became strong in your truth,
and holy in your righteousness.
11 (All my enemies were afraid of me,)
and I became the Lord's, in the Lord's name.
12 By his kindness I was made righteous,
and his rest lasts for ever and ever. Hallelujah.

Chapter 26

Ode 26

1 I poured out praise to the Lord,
because I belong to him.
2 I will speak his holy song,
because my heart is with him.
3 For his harp is in my hands,
and the songs of his rest will not be silent.
4 I will cry to him with my whole heart;
with every limb I will praise and exalt him.
5 His praise reaches from the east to the west,
6 and his thanksgiving from the south to the north,
7 and his perfection from the summit of the hills to their farthest edge.
8 Who can write down the psalms of the Lord,
or who can read them?
9 Or who can train his soul for life,
so that his soul may be saved?

10 Or who can rest on the Most High,
so that he may speak from his mouth?
11 Who can interpret the Lord's wonders? For the one who interprets will be dissolved,
and what is interpreted will remain.
12 It is enough to know, and to rest,
for the singers stand in rest,
13 like a river that has an abundant spring
and flows to help those who seek it. Hallelujah.

Chapter 27

Ode 27

1 I stretched out my hands
and hallowed my Lord,
2 for the stretching of my hands is his sign,
3 and my spreading out is the upright wood. Hallelujah.

Chapter 28

Ode 28

1 As the wings of doves over their young,
and the mouths of their young toward their mouths,
so are the wings of the Spirit over my heart.
2 My heart is glad and leaps,
like the baby that leaps in its mother's womb.
3 I believed, and so I was at rest,
because he in whom I believed is faithful.
4 He has richly blessed me,
and my head is with him.
5 And the sword will not separate me from him,
nor the blade.
6 For I was made ready before destruction came,
and was set on his wings that do not decay.[a]
7 Deathless life embraced me
and kissed me,

[8] and from it comes the Spirit that is in me,
and it cannot die, for it is alive.
[9] Those who saw me were amazed,
because I was being hunted,
[10] and they thought I had been swallowed up,
since to them I looked like one of the lost.
[11] But my oppression became my salvation.
[12] I became their reproach,
because there was no envy in me.
[13] Because I did good to every person,
I was hated.
[14] And they surrounded me like mad dogs,
who in ignorance attack their masters,
[15] for their thinking is corrupt,
and they twist their understanding.
[16] But I held waters in my right hand,
and I bore their bitterness with my sweetness.
[17] I did not perish, because I was not their brother,
and my birth was not like theirs.
[18] They sought my death and did not find it,
because I was older than the memory of them,
and in vain they cast lots against me.
[19] And those who came after me tried in vain to wipe out the memory of him who was before them.
[20] The mind of the Most High cannot be forestalled,
and his heart is greater than all wisdom. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (28:6) The Digital Syriac Corpus numbers this ode in 20 verses and gives Harris and Mingana's numbers, one lower from here on, in brackets. This book follows the 20-verse numbering.

Chapter 29

Ode 29

[1] The Lord is my hope;
I will not be ashamed in him.

2 For he made me according to his glory,
and in the same way he gave to me according to his kindness.
3 He raised me according to his mercies,
and lifted me up according to his great beauty.
4 He brought me up from the depths of Sheol,
and drew me out of the mouth of death.
5 And I laid my enemies low,
6 and he made me righteous by his kindness. For I believed in the Lord's Messiah,
7 and I came to see that he is the Lord. And he showed me his sign,
8 and led me by his light. He gave me the rod of his power,
to bring down the thoughts of the nations
and to humble the strength of the mighty,
9 to wage war with his word,
and to win the victory by his power.
10 The Lord threw down my enemy with his word,
and he became like dust that the wind carries away.
11 I praised the Most High, because he has lifted up his servant
and the son of his maidservant. Hallelujah.

Chapter 30

Ode 30

1 Fill yourselves with water from the Lord's living spring,
because it has been opened for you.
2 And come, all you who are thirsty,
and take the drink, and rest by the Lord's spring.
3 For it is lovely and pure,
and gives rest to the soul.
4 Its waters are far sweeter than honey,
and the honeycomb of bees cannot be compared with it.
5 It flows from the Lord's lips,
and its name came from the Lord's heart.
6 It came without limit and unseen, and
until it was set in the middle, no one knew it.

7 Blessed are those who have drunk of it
and found rest in it. Hallelujah.

Chapter 31

Ode 31

1 The depths were dissolved before the Lord,
and darkness vanished at the sight of him.
2 Error went astray and perished
because of him, and folly (found no path,
and sank) before the Lord's truth.
3 He opened his mouth and spoke kindness
and joy, and he spoke a new song to his name.
4 He lifted his voice to the Most High,
and presented to him the sons who were in his hand.
5 And his face was made righteous,
because his holy Father had given it to him so.
6 Come out, you who were afflicted,
and receive joy.
7 Take possession of your souls through kindness,
and take for yourselves deathless life.
8 They condemned me when I stood up,
though I was not guilty.
9 They divided my spoil,
though nothing was owed to them.
10 But I endured, and was silent, and was still,
as though I were not moved by them.
11 I stood firm, not shaken,
like a solid rock that is beaten by waves and stands.
12 And I bore their bitterness for the sake of gentleness,
to redeem my people and make them heirs,
13 so that I would not cancel my promises to the patriarchs,
to whom I had pledged the redemption of their seed. Hallelujah.

Chapter 32

Ode 32

1 The blessed have joy from their hearts,
and light from him who dwells in them,
2 and the Word from the truth, who came to be from himself.
3 For the Most High's holy power made him strong,
and he is unmoved for ever and ever. Hallelujah.

Chapter 33

Ode 33

1 Again grace ran, and left corruption,
and came down upon it to empty it.
2 And he destroyed perdition before her,
and ruined all its order.
3 He stood on a high place and lifted his voice,
from the far end of the earth to the other.
4 He drew to himself all who obeyed him,
and he did not look like an evil one.
5 But a perfect virgin stood,
who was proclaiming, and calling out, and saying:
6 Children of men, turn back,
and you their daughters, come,
7 and leave the ways of this corruption,
and draw near to me.
8 I will enter into you
and bring you out of destruction,
and make you wise in the ways of truth.
9 Do not be corrupted,
and do not perish.
10 Listen to me and be redeemed,
for the kindness of God is what I speak among you.
11 Through me you will be redeemed
and blessed. I am your judge.
12 Those who put me on will not be wronged,
but will gain a new world without corruption.

13 My chosen ones walked in me,
and I will make my ways known to those who seek me,
and I will make them trust in my name. Hallelujah.

Chapter 34

Ode 34

1 No path is hard where the heart is simple,
nor is there any wound among upright thoughts.
2 Nor is there a storm in the depth of the shining thought.
3 Where a person is surrounded on every side by beauty,
there is nothing divided.
4 The pattern of what is below is what is above.
5 Everything is above,
and below there is nothing,
though those without knowledge imagine it.
6 Grace was revealed for your salvation. Believe,
and you will live, and be saved. Hallelujah.

Chapter 35

Ode 35

1 The dew of the Lord settled on me in rest,
and he raised a cloud of peace over my head,
2 which guarded me at all times,
and became salvation to me.
3 Everything was shaken and frightened,
and smoke and judgment came out from them.
4 But I was quiet under the Lord's decree,
and he was more to me than a shelter, and more than a foundation.
5 I was carried like a child on its mother's lap,
and he gave me milk, the Lord's dew.
6 And I grew by his gift,
and found rest in his perfection.
7 And I stretched out my hands as my soul rose up,
and I was made straight toward the Most High,
and was redeemed to him. Hallelujah.

Chapter 36

Ode 36

1 I rested in the Spirit of the Lord,
and she lifted me up to the height.
2 She set me on my feet in the Lord's height,
before his perfection and his glory,
while I praised him with the composition of his songs.
3 She bore me before the Lord's face,
and though I was a son of man,
I was named the Shining One, the Son of God.
4 For I was glorified among the glorious,
and great among the great.
5 For as great as the Most High is,
so she made me, and by his newness he renewed me.
6 He anointed me out of his perfection,
and I became one of his near ones.
7 My mouth was opened like a dewy cloud,
and my heart poured out a stream of righteousness.
8 I came near in peace,
and was established in the Spirit of guidance. Hallelujah.

Chapter 37

Ode 37

1 I stretched out my hands to my Lord,
and to the Most High I raised my voice.
2 I spoke with my heart's lips,
and he heard me as soon as my voice reached him.
3 His word came to me,
and gave me the fruits of my labors,
4 and gave me rest by the kindness of the Lord. Hallelujah.

Chapter 38

Ode 38

1 I went up into the light of truth as into a chariot,
and truth guided me and carried me.

2 It carried me across pits and chasms,
and rescued me from cliffs and waves.
3 It became a harbor of salvation for me,
and set me on the step of life that has no death.
4 And it went with me, and gave me rest,
and did not let me go astray, because it was truth, and it is.
5 I had no danger, because I walked with it;
and I did not go wrong in anything, because I listened to it.
6 For error ran away from it,
and never met it.
7 And truth walked on the upright road,
and whatever I did not know it showed me,
8 all the poisons of error,
and the scourges which are thought to be death's sweetness.[a]
9 And I saw the destroyer of corruption,
when the corrupting bride was being adorned,
and the bridegroom who corrupts and is corrupted.
10 And I asked the truth, "Who are these?" And it said to me,
"This is the Deceiver and Error."
11 They mimic the Beloved and his bride,
and mislead the world and corrupt it.
12 They invite many to the banquet,
and give them the wine of their drunkenness to drink,
13 and make them vomit up their wisdom
and knowledge, and leave them without sense.
14 Then they abandon them,
and these go about raving and ruined,
15 since they have no heart,
and do not look for one.
16 And I became wise, so as not to fall into the deceivers' hands,
and I rejoiced in myself that truth went with me.[b]
17 I was made firm, and lived,
and was redeemed,
and my foundations were laid on the Lord's hand,

18 because he planted me. He set the root,
watered it, secured it,
and blessed it,
19 and its fruits are for ever. (It went deep, and rose,
and spread out,) and was full and grew great.
20 The Lord alone was glorified,
in his planting and his farming,
21 in his care, and in the blessing of his lips,
in the fair planting by his right hand,
22 and in the skill of his planting,
and in the knowledge of his mind. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (38:8) The Syriac word translated "scourges" (*nāgdē*) can also mean "cords" or "goads".
- b (38:16) From here to the end of the ode the Digital Syriac Corpus also gives Harris and Mingana's numbers in brackets, one lower than those used here; Ode 38 therefore has 22 verses in this book but 21 in their edition.

Chapter 39

Ode 39

1 Mighty rivers are the power of the Lord,
which carry away headlong those who despise him,
2 and tangle their paths,
and ruin their crossings,
3 and snatch their bodies,
and destroy their souls.
4 For they are faster than lightning,
and swifter.
5 But those who cross them in faith will not be shaken,
6 and those who walk through them blamelessly will not fear.
7 For the Lord is the sign in them, and the sign becomes the way
for those who cross in the name of the Lord.
8 So clothe yourselves in the name of the Most High, and know him, and you will cross safely,
since the rivers will be subject to you.

9 The Lord bridged them with his word,
then walked over them and crossed on foot.
10 And his footprints stand on the water
and were not harmed, but are like wood fixed in truth.
11 On this side and on that the waves rose,
but the footprints of our Lord the Messiah stand,
12 and are not blotted out
and are not destroyed.
13 A road has been laid down for those who cross after him, and for those who keep to the way of his faith
and worship his name. Hallelujah.

Chapter 40

Ode 40

1 As honey drips from the combs of bees, and milk runs from a woman who loves her children,
so is my hope on you, my God.
2 As a spring pours out its waters,
so my heart pours forth the Lord's praise,
and my lips bring out praise to him.
3 My tongue is sweet with his words,
and my limbs are made sweet by his songs.[a]
4 My face rejoices in his gladness,
my spirit exults in his love,
and my soul is radiant in him.
5 One who fears will trust in him,
and in him salvation will be sure.
6 His gain is life that does not die,
and those who receive it are without corruption. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (40:3) In the Digital Syriac Corpus some letters of "my limbs" are damaged and supplied by the editors.

Chapter 41

Ode 41

1 Let all his children praise the Lord,
and let them take up the truth of his faith.
2 Let his sons be known to him;
therefore let us sing in his love.
3 We live in the Lord by his kindness,
and we receive life by his Messiah.
4 For a great day has dawned on us,
and wonderful is he who gave us of his glory.
5 So let us all together be united in the name of the Lord,
and honor him in his goodness.
6 May our faces shine in his light,
and our hearts reflect on his love,
night and day.
7 Let us rejoice with the joy of the Lord.
8 Let everyone who sees me be astonished,
because I come from a different race.
9 The Father of truth remembered me,
who acquired me from the beginning.
10 For his riches bore me,
and the thought of his heart.
11 His Word is with us on all our road,
the Savior who gives life and does not cast out our souls.
12 He is the man who humbled himself,
and was lifted up by his own righteousness.
13 The Son of the Most High was seen in his Father's perfection,
14 and light dawned from the Word who was in him from of old.
15 The Messiah is truly one,
and was known before the foundations of the world, …[a]
16 so that he might give souls life for ever through the truth of his name. A new song of praise to the Lord from those who love him. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (41:15) The corpus text marks a gap in the manuscript after "foundations of the world".

Chapter 42

Ode 42

1 I stretched out my hands and came near to my Lord,
for the stretching of my hands is his sign.
2 And my spreading out is the upright wood,
that was hung on the way of the Upright One.
3 And I was of no use to those who knew me,
because I was hidden from those who did not hold me.[a]
4 But I will be with those who love me.
5 All my persecutors are dead, and they sought me,
those who had put their hope in me, because I live.
6 I rose, and I am with them,
and I will speak through their mouths.
7 For they put away those who pursued them,
and I laid on them the yoke of my love.
8 As the bridegroom's arm rests over the bride,
so my yoke rests over those who know me.
9 And as the bridal chamber is spread out in the house of the bridegrooms,
so is my love over those who believe in me.
10 I was not cast out, though they thought so;
and I did not perish, though they planned it against me.
11 Sheol saw me and was afflicted,
and death gave me up, and many with me.
12 I was gall and bitterness to it,
and I descended with it to the limit of its depth.
13 And I let go its feet and head,
because they could not bear my face.
14 And I made a congregation of the living among its dead,
and spoke with them with living lips,
so that my word would not be in vain.
15 And those who had died ran to me, and cried out
and said, "Have pity on us, Son of God,

16 and act toward us in your kindness,
and bring us out from the chains of darkness,
17 and open
for us the door through which we may come out to you. For we see that death has not touched you.
18 May we also be redeemed with you,
for you are our Redeemer."
19 And I heard their voice,
and set their faith in my heart,
20 and set my name on their heads,
for they are free and are mine. Hallelujah.

Notes

- a (42:3) Verses 3 and 7 are difficult in the Syriac, and the sense given here is uncertain.

Life of Adam and Eve

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 After they were driven out of paradise, they built themselves a hut
and spent seven days mourning and wailing in deep sorrow. 2 When
the seven days were over, they began to feel hungry, and they looked
for something to eat, but could find nothing.

Chapter 2

1 Then Eve spoke to Adam: "Master, I am starving. Go and find us
something to eat. 2 Perhaps the Lord God will look on us again and
take pity, and call us back to the place where we used to be." 3 So Adam
got up and walked for seven days across the whole country, and he
found no food like the food they had had in paradise.

Chapter 3

1 Then Eve said to Adam, "My lord, you would do better to kill me,
so that I die. Perhaps then the Lord God will bring you back into
paradise, because it was on my account that the Lord God was angry
with you. 2 Do you want to put me to death? Perhaps the Lord God
will bring you into paradise again, since it was because of me that
you were driven out." 3 Adam answered, "Eve, do not talk like that, or
the Lord God may bring another curse on us. How could I raise my
hand against my own flesh? 4 No, let us get up and look for something
to live on, so that we do not waste away."

Chapter 4

1 So they set out and went on searching for nine days, and found
nothing like what they had had in paradise. They found only what
the animals ate. 2 Then Adam said to Eve, "The Lord gave this food
to the animals and wild beasts to eat. We used to have the food of
angels. 3 It is right and proper that we should grieve before the face

of God who made us. Let us do great penance. Perhaps the Lord God will forgive us, take pity on us, and provide a way for us to live."

Chapter 5

1 Eve said to Adam, "My lord, tell me what penance is and how I should do it. I am afraid we may take on a burden we cannot bear, and then he will not hear our prayers, and the Lord will turn his face away from us, because we have not kept what we promised. 2 My lord, you have thought how much you are willing to bear in penance, because I brought this toil and trouble on you."

Chapter 6

1 Adam said to Eve, "You cannot do as much as I can. Do only as much as will save you. 2 I will fast for forty days. You must get up and go to the river Tigris, find a stone, step onto it in the current, and stay where the river is deep enough to reach your neck. 3 No word is to come out of your mouth, because we are not fit to pray to the Lord; our lips are unclean from the forbidden tree we were told not to touch. 4 Stand in the water of the river for thirty-seven days. I will stand in the water of the Jordan for forty days. Perhaps the Lord God will take pity on us."

Chapter 7

1 Eve went to the river Tigris and did what Adam had told her. 2 Adam in the same way went to the Jordan and took his stand on a stone, the water reaching his neck.

Chapter 8

1 Adam said, "Waters of the Jordan, I am speaking to you: suffer with me. Gather to me all the creatures that swim in you, so that they surround me and mourn with me. 2 Let them not lament for themselves, but for me, because it was not they who sinned, but I." 3 Immediately all the living creatures came and crowded around him, and from that hour the Jordan's water halted and did not flow.

Chapter 9

1 When eighteen days had passed, Satan became angry. He changed
himself into the brightness of the angels, went to the river Tigris,
to Eve, and found her weeping. 2 The devil himself, as if he grieved
for her, began to cry and told her, "Leave the river, and stop your
weeping. Stop your sadness and your groaning now. 3 Why are you
so anxious, you and your husband Adam? The Lord God has heard
your groaning and accepted your penance, and all of us angels have
begged the Lord on your behalf. 4 He has sent me to lead you from
the water and to give you the food you used to have in paradise, the
food you have been mourning for. 5 So come out of the water now,
and I will lead you to the place where your food is ready."

Chapter 10

1 When Eve heard this, she believed him. She left the river, and her
skin looked like grass shriveled by the chill of the water. 2 As she
climbed out she collapsed on the ground; the devil lifted her to her
feet and took her to Adam. 3 When Adam saw her and the devil with
her, he cried out in tears, "Oh, Eve, Eve! Where is the work of your
penance? 4 How have you been deceived again by our enemy, the one
who caused us to be shut out of our home in paradise and from its
spiritual joy?"

Chapter 11

1 When Eve heard this, she realized that the devil had talked her into
leaving the river. She fell on her face on the ground, and her grief and
groaning and lamenting were doubled. 2 She cried out, "Curse you,
devil! Why do you attack us for nothing? What do you have against
us? What have we done to you, that you pursue us so cunningly?
What does your wickedness have to do with us? 3 Did we take your
glory away and leave you without honor? Why do you hound us to
death, you wicked and spiteful enemy?"

Chapter 12

1 The devil groaned and said, "Adam, all my hostility and envy and
pain are aimed at you. Because of you I was driven out and cut off

from the glory that I had in heaven among the angels, and because of you I was thrown down to earth." 2 Adam answered, "What have I done to you? What is my fault against you? You have not been harmed or hurt by us, so why do you hunt us down?"

Chapter 13

1 The devil answered, "Adam, what are you saying to me? It is because of you that I was thrown out. When you were formed, I was thrown out from God's presence and sent away from the company of the angels. 2 When God breathed the breath of life into you, and your face and likeness were made in the image of God, Michael brought you and made you bow down in the sight of God. And the Lord God said, 'See, Adam, I have made you in our image and likeness.'"

Chapter 14

1 "Michael went out and summoned every angel: 'Bow down to the image of the Lord God, as the Lord God has ordered.' Michael was the first to bow. Next he summoned me and said, 'Bow down to the image of God, Yahweh.' 2 My answer was, 'Worshiping Adam is not something I have to do.' But Michael kept urging me to bow, and I said to him, 'Why are you forcing me? I will not worship one who is lower than I am and came after me. In creation I am older than he is. Before he was made, I had already been made. He ought to worship me.'"

Chapter 15

1 "The other angels who served under me heard this, and they also refused to bow to him. Michael said, 'Worship the image of God. If you do not, the Lord God will be angry with you.' 2 And I said, 'If he is angry with me, I will set my throne above the stars of heaven and be like the Most High.'"

Chapter 16

1 "The Lord God was angry with me, and sent me out with my angels from our glory. Because of you we were driven out of our homes into this world and thrown down on the earth. 2 At once we were in pain, because we had been stripped of such great glory. And it hurt us to

see you in such great delight. 3 So I tricked your wife by deceit, and through her I had you driven out of your joyful delights, just as I was driven out of my glory."

Chapter 17

1 When Adam heard this from the devil, he cried out in great tears and said, "Lord my God, my life is in your hands. Keep this enemy of mine far from me, he who is trying to destroy my soul, and give me the glory that he himself has lost." 2 At once the devil disappeared from his sight. And Adam stayed on, standing in penance in the water of the Jordan for forty days.

Chapter 18

1 Eve said to Adam, "Live, my lord. Life has been granted to you, because you were not guilty of the first or the second transgression. It was I who broke the commandment and was led astray, because I did not keep the command of God. 2 Now send me away from the light of this life. I will go to the west, where the sun sets, and stay there until I die." 3 She began to walk toward the western regions, and she began to mourn and weep bitterly with loud groaning. There she made herself a shelter, carrying a child of three months in her womb.

Chapter 19

1 When the time of her delivery came near, she began to be tormented by pains. She cried out to the Lord, "Have mercy on me, Lord; help me." But she was not heard, and God's mercy did not come to her. 2 Then she said to herself, "Who will tell my lord Adam? I beg you, lights of heaven, when you return to the east, tell my lord Adam."

Chapter 20

1 At that very hour Adam said, "I hear Eve crying out. Perhaps the serpent is fighting with her again." 2 He walked on and came upon her in terrible distress. Eve said, "From the moment I saw you, my lord, my soul, caught in its pains, was refreshed. 3 Now pray to the Lord God for me, so that he will hear you and look on me and free me from these terrible pains." And Adam prayed to the Lord for Eve.

Chapter 21

1 Then twelve angels came, with two powers, who stood on the right
and left of Eve. Michael stood on her right, touched her face down to
her breast, and said to her, "You are blessed, Eve, because of Adam.
His prayers and entreaties are great, and I have been sent to you so
that you can receive our help. 2 Get up now and prepare for the birth."
She gave birth to a son, and he shone with light. 3 The baby at once
rose and ran; he plucked some grass with his own hands and handed
it to his mother. His name was called Cain.

Chapter 22

1 Adam took Eve and the boy and led them to the east. 2 The Lord God
sent the angel Michael with seeds of various kinds. He handed them
to Adam and taught him to till the soil and tend it, so that they would
have fruit to live on, they and all their descendants.

Chapter 23

1 After that Eve conceived again and bore a son named Abel. Cain
stayed together with Abel. 2 Eve said to Adam, "My lord, I had a vision
in my sleep: I saw the blood of our son Abel in Cain's hand, and Cain
was swallowing it down with his mouth. That is why I am troubled."
3 Adam said, "Oh no! May Cain not kill Abel! Let us separate them
from each other and give each of them a separate home." 4 They made
Cain a farmer and Abel a shepherd, to keep them apart. But after this
Cain killed Abel. Adam was then 130 years old, and Abel was 122
when he was killed.

Chapter 24

1 After this Adam knew his wife and she bore a son, and he named
him Seth. Adam said to Eve, "See, I have had a son to replace Abel,
the one Cain killed." 2 After Seth was born, Adam lived another eight
hundred years and had thirty sons and thirty daughters, sixty-three
in all.[a] They multiplied over the earth, in their nations.

Notes

- a (24:2) The Latin says "sixty-three" (*LXIII*), but thirty sons and thirty daughters make sixty; the figure is kept as the manuscripts give it.

Chapter 25

1 Adam said to Seth, "Listen, my son Seth, and I will tell you what I
heard and saw. After my wife, your mother, and I were driven out of
paradise, while we were praying, the archangel Michael, a messenger
of God, came to me. 2 I saw a chariot that moved like the wind, with
wheels of fire, and I was carried off to the paradise of righteousness. 3
I saw the Lord seated, and his appearance was a blazing fire, unbear-
able. And many thousands of angels stood to the right and left of his
chariot."

Chapter 26

1 "When I saw this, I was terrified. Fear seized me, and I bowed
down before God, face to the ground. 2 God said to me, 'See, you will
die, because you went against God's command: you listened to your
wife's voice more than to mine, though I gave her into your power
to have her at your will. You listened to her, and my words you
disregarded.'"

Chapter 27

1 "At these words of God I fell to the ground, bowed to the Lord, and
said, 'My Lord, almighty God, merciful, holy, and loving, do not let the
name of your majesty's memory be wiped out. 2 Turn my soul back,
for I am dying and my breath will leave my mouth. Do not cast me
from your presence, I whom you formed from the clay of the earth,
and do not put aside your grace for the one you nourished. 3 See, your
word comes to me.' And the Lord said to me, 'Because your days are
numbered, you have become a lover of knowledge; for this reason it
will not be taken away from your seed for ever, to serve me.'"[a]

Notes

- a (27:3) The Latin of the last clause is obscure (*quoniam figurantur dies tui factus es diligens scientiam*), and the translation is a best guess at its sense.

Chapter 28

1 "After hearing this I lay face down on the ground and bowed before
the Lord God, saying, 'You are the eternal and most high God, and all
creatures give you honor and praise. 2 You are the true light, shining

above every light, the living life, a power of incomprehensible greatness. The spiritual powers give you honor and praise. [3] You work the great wonders of your mercy with the human race.'"

Chapter 29

[1] "After I worshiped the Lord, the archangel Michael at once took my hand and led me out of the paradise of God's visitation and command. [2] Michael had a rod in his hand. He touched the waters around paradise, and they turned to ice. I crossed over, and Michael crossed with me, and brought me back to the place from which he had taken me. [3] Listen, my son Seth, to the other mysteries and secrets of what is to come, which were revealed to me, who ate from the tree of knowledge and came to know and understand what will happen in this world." [4] ... what will happen in this age, what God will do for his creature, the human race. The Lord will appear in a blaze of fire. Out of his majestic mouth he will give everyone commands and rules (from his mouth a sword will come, sharp on both sides), and in the house where his majesty dwells they will hallow him. And he will show them the wonderful place of his majesty.[a] [5] Then they will build a house for the Lord their God on the earth, in the land where he fed them (the land he will prepare for them). There they will disobey his commands, their sanctuary will be set on fire, and their land will be left desolate, and they themselves will be scattered, because they have angered God. Yet again (on the third day, or the seventh) he will save them from their scattering, and they will build the house of God once more, and at the last that house will be lifted higher than it was before. And again wickedness will overcome justice. [6] After that God will live among people on earth, to be seen. Then justice will begin to shine. The house of God will be honored for ever, and hostile powers will no longer be able to harm those who believe in God. For himself God will bring forth a loyal people, and he will keep them safe for all ages. The wicked who refused to love his law will be punished by God their king. Heaven and earth, night and day, and all creatures will obey him; they will not go beyond his command or change their works. But people will change, abandoning the law of

the Lord. 7 For this the Lord will drive the wicked away from himself, and the righteous will gleam like the sun before God's eyes. At that time people will be cleansed of their sins by water; but those who refuse to be cleansed by water will be condemned. Happy will be the person who has set his soul right, when the judgments and great deeds of God take place among people, and their actions are examined by God, the righteous judge.

Notes

- a (29:4) Verses 4–7 (marked "a–d" in Meyer's edition) are an addition found in only some of the Latin manuscripts. The Latin of this passage is uneven, and words in round brackets are variants or additions printed in the Latin text itself.

Chapter 30

1 In the 930th year of his life, Adam knew that his days were running out, and he said, "Gather all my sons around me, so that I may speak with them and give them my blessing before I die." 2 They gathered in three groups before him, in front of the prayer house where they used to worship the Lord God. They asked him, "Father, what is wrong? Why did you call us together, and why are you lying in your bed?" 3 Adam answered, "My children, I am in pain and I am ill." All his sons said to him, "Father, what does it mean to be ill with pain?"

Chapter 31

1 Then his son Seth said, "Lord, perhaps you are longing for the fruit of paradise that you used to eat, and that is why you are lying here grieved? Say the word, and I will go to the gates of paradise nearest us, sprinkle dust on my head, lie on the ground in front of the gates, and cry out in great lament, pleading with the Lord. Perhaps he will listen and send his angel to fetch me some of the fruit you crave." 2 Adam answered, "No, my son, that is not what I want. What I have is an illness, and a great pain in my body." 3 Seth said, "Father and lord, I do not know what pain is. Do not hide it from us, but tell us."

Chapter 32

1 Adam answered, "Listen to me, my children. At our creation, mine and your mother's, God placed us in paradise. Every fruit tree there

was given to us for food, but he forbade us: 'Do not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, which stands in the middle of paradise.' [2] He shared out paradise between your mother and me. I received the eastern trees and those of the northern side, which faces the north wind; to your mother he gave the southern part and the western."

Chapter 33

[1] "The Lord God gave us two angels to guard us. When the hour came for the angels to go up to worship in the sight of God, the enemy, the devil, found his chance, while the angels were absent. [2] The devil deceived your mother into eating from the forbidden tree we were told not to touch. She ate, and gave to me."

Chapter 34

[1] "The Lord God grew angry with us at once. He told me, 'You abandoned my commandment and did not obey the word I laid on you, I will bring seventy blows on your body. You will be tormented in every limb with different pains, from the top of the head, and the eyes and ears, to the nails of the feet.' [2] He appointed these as a scourge … together with the trees.[a] [3] The Lord sent all these things on me and on all our generations."

Notes

- a (34:2) The Latin of this sentence is corrupt: Meyer marks *dolori* with crosses (*Haec deputavit in flagellationem + dolori + uno cum arboribus*), and no sure sense can be recovered. The Greek *Apocalypse of Moses* (ch. 8) also speaks of seventy blows, each affecting a different part of the body.

Chapter 35

[1] After saying this to all his children, Adam was seized by great pains. He cried out loudly: "What shall I do, wretched as I am, caught in such pain?" [2] When Eve saw him weeping, she too began to weep, saying, "Lord my God, put his pain on me, because I am the one who sinned." [3] Eve said to Adam, "My master, let me carry part of your pains, because this guilt came to you through me."

Chapter 36

1 Adam said to Eve, “Get up and go with my son Seth to the edge of
paradise. Put dust on your heads, throw yourselves on the ground,
and mourn in the sight of God. 2 Perhaps he will take pity and send
his angel to the tree of his mercy, from which the oil of life flows, and
give you a little of it, so that you can anoint me with it and I can rest
from these pains that are wearing me away.”

Chapter 37

1 Seth and his mother set out toward the gates of paradise. As they
were walking, suddenly a beast, a serpent, came, rushed at Seth, and
bit him. 2 When Eve saw it, she wept and said, “Woe to me, wretched
woman, for I am cursed, because I did not keep the Lord’s command-
ments.” 3 Eve shouted at the serpent, “Cursed beast, how were you
not afraid to throw yourself at the image of God, but dared to fight
with it? How did your teeth prevail?”

Chapter 38

1 The beast answered in a human voice, “Eve, is our wickedness not
aimed at you? Is our rage not against you? Tell me, Eve, how was
your mouth opened to eat the fruit that the Lord God commanded
you not to eat? If I begin to reproach you now, can you bear it?”

Chapter 39

1 Then Seth said to the beast, “The Lord God rebuke you. Be silent,
be dumb, shut your mouth, you cursed enemy of the truth, confusion
of destruction. Stay clear of God’s image until the day the Lord God
commands that you be brought to trial.” 2 The beast said to Seth, “See,
as you say, I am leaving the presence of the image of God.” At once
the wound left Seth’s flesh from the bite.

Chapter 40

1 Seth and his mother kept going toward the edges of paradise, to fetch
the oil of mercy and rub it on the ailing Adam. 2 When they reached
the gates of paradise, they picked up dust from the ground and put
it on their heads. They threw themselves on the ground, face down,

and began to wail with loud groaning, asking the Lord God to have mercy on Adam in his agony and to send his angel with oil from the tree of his mercy.

Chapter 41

1 After they had been praying and begging for many hours, the angel Michael appeared before them. "The Lord has sent me to you," he said. "I am the one appointed by the Lord over the human body. 2 I tell you, Seth, man of God, stop weeping and pleading for the oil of the tree of mercy, which you want in order to soothe your father Adam's bodily pains."

Chapter 42

1 "I tell you that you will not be able to get any of it, except in the last days, when five thousand five hundred years have passed. 2 Then the most loving king, Christ, the Son of God, will come on the earth to raise up Adam's body and with it to raise the bodies of the dead. On his coming, the Son of God himself will be baptized in the river Jordan, and as he rises out of the Jordan's water he will anoint with the oil of his mercy all who believe in him. 3 The oil of mercy will be for generation after generation for those who are to be born again of water and the Holy Spirit into eternal life. Then the most loving Son of God, Christ, coming down to earth, will lead your father Adam into paradise, to the tree of mercy."[a]

Notes

- a (42:3) This prophecy is a Christian addition: it speaks of Christ's baptism and of the world lasting five thousand five hundred years before his coming, a count common in early Christian chronology. The Greek *Apocalypse of Moses* (ch. 13) also says that Seth cannot have the oil now, only at the end.

Chapter 43

1 "But you, Seth, go to your father Adam, because the time of his life is complete. Six more days, and then his soul will leave his body. When it leaves, you will see great wonders in heaven and on earth and in the lights of heaven." 2 After saying this, Michael left Seth at once.

Eve and Seth turned back. They took spices with them: nard, saffron, calamint, and cinnamon.

Chapter 44

1 When Seth and his mother came to Adam, they told him that the serpent beast had bitten Seth. Adam said to Eve, "What have you done? You have brought a great plague on us, guilt and sin on all our generations. 2 And what you have done will fall on your children after my death … because those who rise from us will labor and not be strong enough, but will fail, and will curse us, saying, 'Our parents, who lived at the beginning, brought all these evils on us.'"[a] 3 When Eve heard this, she began to weep and groan.

Notes

- a (44:2) The Latin has *+ refert +* between crosses here, meaning that the word is corrupt; the translation leaves the gap marked.

Chapter 45

1 Just as the archangel Michael had foretold, Adam's death came after six days. When Adam realized that the hour of his death had come, he said to all his sons, "See, I am 930 years old. If I die, bury me toward the east, in … the great dwelling-place of God."[a] 2 When he had finished all his words, he gave up his spirit.

Notes

- a (45:1) The Latin reads *contra + ortum + dei magnum habitationibus*; the word *ortum* is marked as corrupt (it could mean "sunrise" or "garden").

Chapter 46

1 The sun, the moon, and the stars were darkened for seven days. Seth lay over his father's body, embracing it and mourning. Eve stood looking at the ground, with her hands clasped over her head and her head bent down on her knees, and all his children wept with bitter tears. 2 Then the angel Michael appeared, standing at Adam's head, and said to Seth, "Get up from your father's body and come to me, and see what the Lord God has decided about him. He is his creature, and God has pitied him."

Chapter 47

1 All the angels sounded their trumpets and said, “Blessed are you,
Lord, because you have taken pity on what you formed.” 2 Then Seth
saw the hand of the Lord stretched out, holding Adam, and the Lord
handed him to Michael, saying, “Let him be in your keeping until the
day of the dispensation, in the punishments, for the last years, when
I will turn his mourning to joy. Then he will sit on the throne of the
one who tripped him up.”[a]

Notes

- a (47:2) “The one who tripped him up” (Latin *qui eum supplantavit*) is the devil. The sense is that Adam will take the place that the devil lost.

Chapter 48

1 Then the Lord said again to the angels Michael and Uriel, “Bring me
three linen cloths and spread them over Adam. And bring others for
his son Abel, and bury Adam and his son.” 2 All the powers of the
angels went before Adam, and the resting of the dead was made holy.
Michael and Uriel buried Adam and Abel in the regions of paradise,
while Seth and his mother watched, and no one else. 3 And Michael
and Uriel said, “As you have seen, bury your dead the same way.”

Chapter 49

1 Six days after Adam died, Eve knew that her own death was near.
She called all her sons and daughters together, who were Seth with
his thirty brothers and thirty sisters, and she said to them all, “Listen
to me, my children, and I will tell you what happened: your father and
I broke God’s command. 2 The archangel Michael told us, ‘Because of
your transgressions our Lord will bring the anger of his judgment on
your race, first by water and then by fire. By these two the Lord will
judge the whole human race.’”

Chapter 50

1 “But listen to me, my children. Make tablets of stone and others of
clay, and write on them all my life and your father’s life, everything
you heard and saw from us. 2 If he judges our race by water, the clay
tablets will dissolve and the stone ones will stay. If he judges our race

by fire, the stone tablets will break up and the clay ones will be baked hard."[a] [3] When Eve had said all this to her children, she stretched her hands toward heaven in prayer, bent her knees to the ground, worshiped the Lord, and gave thanks, and she gave up her spirit.

Notes

- a (50:2) The Latin has the nonsense word *nosbllum* in both places, which I read as *nostrum*, "our."

Chapter 51

[1] After that all her sons buried her with great weeping. When they had mourned for four days, the archangel Michael appeared to them and said to Seth, "Man of God, do not mourn for your dead more than six days. The seventh day is the sign of the resurrection and of the rest of the age to come; for on the seventh day the Lord rested from all his works." [2] Then Seth made the tablets. [3] Then Seth made (two) tablets of stone and (two) of clay, (and he set out the letters), and he wrote on them the life of his father Adam and his mother Eve, which he had heard from them and seen with his own eyes. He put the tablets in the middle of his father's house, in the prayer house where he prayed to the Lord. After the flood many people saw those written tablets, but no one could read them.[a] [4] Solomon the wise saw the writing, and he prayed to the Lord, and an angel of the Lord appeared to him and said, "I am the one who held Seth's hand while he wrote these stones with his finger. You will understand the writing, so that you know and understand what all these stones contain, and where the prayer house was, where Adam and Eve worshiped the Lord God. You must build a temple of the Lord there, that is, a house of prayer." [5] Then Solomon completed the temple of the Lord God, and he called those letters *achiliacas*, "written without words to teach them," (written) with Seth's finger, with the angel of the Lord holding his hand.[b] [6] And on those same stones was found what Enoch, the seventh from Adam, prophesied before the flood about the coming of Christ: "See, the Lord will come with his holy ones to carry out judgment on all, and to convict the wicked of all the works they have done against

him, the sinners and the wicked, the grumblers and the ungodly, who walk after their own desires, and whose mouths speak arrogance."[c]

Notes

- a (51:3) Verses 3–6 (marked "a–d" in Meyer's edition) are an ending found in only some of the Latin manuscripts; it is included here as part of the text that Meyer prints.
- b (51:5) The Latin *achiliacas* may be a corruption of a Greek word; the Latin itself explains it as "written without the teaching of words."
- c (51:6) This is the prophecy of Enoch quoted in the New Testament letter of Jude, verses 14–16; compare 1 Enoch 1:9.

Joseph and Aseneth

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 During the first of the seven plentiful years, in the second month (April–May),[a] on the fifth day of the month, Pharaoh[b] sent Joseph[c] out to make a circuit of the whole land of Egypt.[d] 2 In the fourth month (June–July), on the eighteenth day of the month, in that first year, Joseph came to the territory of Heliopolis.[e] 3 He was gathering in the grain of that region, and it was piled up like the sand of the sea. 4 Now in that city there was a man who was a satrap of Pharaoh, the chief of all Pharaoh's satraps and nobles. 5 This man was very rich, wise, and gentle; he was a counselor to Pharaoh. His name was Pentephres,[f] and he was a priest of Heliopolis. 6 Pentephres had a daughter, a virgin about eighteen years old, tall and lovely, and more strikingly beautiful than any other virgin on earth. 7 She was not at all like the daughters of the Egyptians; in every way she was like the daughters of the Hebrews. 8 She was tall like Sarah,[g] lovely like Rebecca,[h] and beautiful like Rachel.[i] The name of this virgin was Aseneth.[j] 9 The report of her beauty spread through that whole country and to its farthest edges, and all the sons of the nobles, the satraps, and the kings wanted to marry her; they were all young men. 10 There was bitter rivalry among them over her, and they tried to make war on one another because of Aseneth. 11 The firstborn son of Pharaoh heard about her, and he kept begging his father to give her to him as his wife. 12 He would say to him, "Give me Aseneth, the daughter of Pentephres, the priest of Heliopolis, to be my wife." 13 His father Pharaoh answered him, "Why are you looking for a wife beneath you? Are you not king of the whole world? 14 Look, the daughter of King Joakim[k] is already promised to you, and she is a queen of great beauty. Take her for your wife."

Notes

- a (1:1) The Greek counts months by number, as the Hebrew calendar does, and gives no month name. The Hebrew year is lunar, so each month falls across two months of our calendar. The book does not say whether it counts from the spring or from another starting point; the spring-start count is used here. "Second month" corresponds to Iyyar (April–May) and "fourth month" (verse 2) to Tammuz (June–July).
- b (1:1) "Pharaoh" is the Egyptian royal title *per-aa*, "great house."
- c (1:1) Hebrew *Yosef*, "may he add" (Genesis 30:24).
- d (1:1) Hebrew *Mitsrayim*; the meaning of the name is unknown.
- e (1:2) Greek *Heliopolis* means "city of the sun." The Egyptian name was *Iunu*, and the Bible calls it On (Genesis 41:45).
- f (1:5) Greek form of the Egyptian name that appears in Genesis as Potiphera; it is usually explained as "the one whom (the sun god) Re has given."
- g (1:8) Hebrew *Sarah*, "princess."
- h (1:8) Hebrew *Rivqah*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "tied" or "a rope."
- i (1:8) Hebrew *Rachel*, "ewe."
- j (1:8) Greek *Asenet*, from the Egyptian name given in Genesis 41:45 as Asenath. It is usually explained as "she belongs to (the goddess) Neith."
- k (1:14) Greek form of Jehoiakim, Hebrew *Yehoyaqim*, "Yahweh raises up." The book places him anachronistically at Pharaoh's court; the passage may be a later insertion.

Chapter 2

1 Aseneth despised every man and spat on them, and no man had ever
seen her. For next to Pentephres' house there stood a tower, very large
and very high. 2 On top of the tower was an upper floor containing
ten rooms. 3 The first room was large and handsome. Its floor was
paved with purple stone, and its walls were faced with costly stones
of many colors. 4 The ceiling of that room was gold. Inside it stood
countless gods of the Egyptians, made of gold and silver. 5 Aseneth
revered all of them, and feared them, and offered sacrifices to them.
6 The second room held all of Aseneth's ornaments and her chests. 7
In it there was a great deal of gold and silver, clothing woven with
gold thread, precious chosen stones, and fine linen. 8 There lay all the
finery of her maidenhood. 9 The third room was full of all the good
things of the earth; it was Aseneth's storeroom. 10 The other seven
rooms were occupied by seven virgins, one to each room. 11 These
waited on Aseneth. They were all of her age, because they had been
born on the same night as Aseneth, and they were as beautiful as

the stars of heaven. No man had ever spoken with them, nor even a male child. 12 There were three windows in the large room of Aseneth where her maidenhood was kept. 13 One window looked out on the courtyard to the east, the second looked north to the street, and the third faced south. 14 A golden couch stood in the room, facing east. 15 The couch was spread with a purple covering woven with gold thread, in blue and fine linen. 16 On this couch Aseneth slept alone, and no man or woman ever sat on it except Aseneth herself. 17 A great courtyard lay all around the house, with a very high wall around the courtyard, built of great squared stones. 18 The courtyard had four iron-plated gates, and each was guarded by eighteen strong young armed men. 19 Along the wall inside the courtyard were planted fine fruit trees of every kind, and all their fruit was ripe, for it was harvest time. 20 On the right side of the courtyard was a rich spring of water. Below the spring was a great basin that received its water, and from there a stream ran through the middle of the courtyard and watered all the trees in it.

Chapter 3

1 In the fourth month (June–July), on the eighteenth day of the month, Joseph came to the territory of Heliopolis. 2 When he drew near the city, Joseph sent twelve men ahead of him to Pentephres, the priest of Heliopolis, with this message: 3 "I will stay with you today, since it is midday, the time for the noon meal, and the heat of the sun is great, and I would like to rest under your roof." 4 Pentephres heard this and was overjoyed, and said, "Blessed be the Lord,[a] the God of Joseph." 5 He called the steward of his house and said to him, 6 "Hurry and get my house ready, and prepare a great banquet, because Joseph, the mighty one of God, is coming to us today." 7 Aseneth heard that her parents had come back from the fields of their estate, and she was glad, and said, 8 "I must go and see my father and mother, since they have come back from the fields of our estate." 9 Aseneth hurried and put on a robe of fine linen, blue and woven with gold. She tied on a golden belt, put bracelets on her arms and ankles, wore golden trousers, and hung a necklace around her neck. 10 Costly stones were set all over these

things, with the names of the Egyptian gods carved everywhere on the bracelets and the stones; and the faces of the idols were engraved in the stones. 11 On her head she put a tiara and a diadem, and bound it tight around her temples, and wrapped her head in a veil.

Notes

- a (3:4) The Greek text always says *kyrios*, "Lord," and *theos*, "God." No Hebrew name of God appears in it, so the CJT keeps "Lord" and "God" here and does not write "Yahweh." In the Jewish Bible the God of Joseph is Yahweh.

Chapter 4

1 She hurried down the stairs from her upper floor, went to her father and mother, and greeted them. 2 Pentephres and his wife were filled with joy over their daughter Aseneth, because her parents saw her dressed like a bride of God. 3 They brought out all the good things they had carried back from their estate in the fields, and gave them to their daughter. 4 Aseneth was delighted with the produce, the grapes, the dates, the pigeons, the pomegranates, and the figs, because they were all beautiful. 5 Pentephres said to his daughter Aseneth, "Child." She said, "Here I am, my lord." He said to her, "Sit between us, and I will tell you what I have to say." 6 Aseneth sat down between her father and mother. 7 Her father Pentephres took her right hand in his right hand and said, "Child." Aseneth said, "Let my lord and father speak." 8 Pentephres said to her, "Look, Joseph, the mighty one of God, is coming to us today. He is the ruler of the whole land of Egypt; Pharaoh appointed him ruler over our whole land, and he distributes grain to the whole country and saves it from the famine that is coming. 9 Joseph is a man who reveres God, self-controlled, and a virgin as you are today. He is a man powerful in wisdom and knowledge, the spirit of God is on him, and the favor of the Lord is with him. 10 Come now, my child, and I will give you to him as his wife; you will be his bride, and he will be your bridegroom forever." 11 When Aseneth heard her father's words, a great red sweat poured over her; she flared up in a great rage, looked at her father with a sideways glare, and said, 12 "Why does my lord and father speak like this? Does he want to hand me over, like a captive, to a foreigner, a

fugitive, and a man who was sold? 13 Is he not the shepherd's son out
of the land of Canaan,[a] who was himself abandoned by his father? 14 Is
he not the one who slept with his mistress, and his master threw him
into the dark prison, and Pharaoh brought him out of prison because
he interpreted his dream? 15 No! I will marry the king's firstborn son,
because he is king of the whole earth." 16 When Pentephres heard this,
he was ashamed to say anything more to his daughter about Joseph,
since she had answered him with such arrogance and anger.

Notes

- a (4:13) Hebrew *Kenaʿan*; the meaning is uncertain, possibly "lowland" or "merchant."

Chapter 5

1 Just then a young man ran out from Pentephres' servants and said,
"Look, Joseph is at the doors of our courtyard." 2 Aseneth fled from the
sight of her parents, and went up to the upper floor and into her room,
and stood at the great window that looked east, to see the one who
was coming into her father's house. 3 Pentephres and his wife and all
his relatives went out to meet Joseph. 4 The gates of the courtyard
that face east were opened, and Joseph came in, riding in Pharaoh's
second chariot. 5 Four horses were yoked to it, white as snow, with
golden bridles, and the chariot was canopied in gold. 6 Joseph was
dressed in a splendid white tunic, and the robe he wore over it was
purple linen woven with gold. A golden crown was on his head, and
around the crown were twelve chosen stones, and over the stones
rose twelve golden rays; and a royal scepter was in his right hand. 7
He also held out an olive branch, heavy with fruit. 8 Joseph entered
the courtyard, and the gates were shut. 9 Any man or woman who
was a stranger stayed outside, because the gatekeepers had closed
the doors. 10 Pentephres, his wife, and all his relatives came, all but
their daughter Aseneth, and bowed to Joseph with their faces to the
ground. 11 Joseph stepped down from his chariot and gave them his
right hand in greeting.

Chapter 6

1 When Aseneth saw Joseph, she was pierced to the soul; her insides twisted, her knees went slack, and her whole body shook. She was seized with great fear, and she groaned and said, 2 "Where can I go, and where can I hide from his face? How will Joseph, the son of God,[a] ever look at me, since I have spoken evil of him? 3 Where can I flee and hide? He sees every hiding place, and nothing hidden escapes him, because of the great light within him. 4 Now may the God of Joseph be merciful to me, because I spoke wicked words in ignorance. 5 What am I to do, wretched as I am? Did I not say, 'Here comes Joseph, the shepherd's son from the land of Canaan'? And now, look, the sun has come down from heaven to us in his chariot and entered our house today. 6 What a fool I was, and how reckless, to despise him and to say wicked things about him, not knowing that Joseph is a son of God. 7 For what man will ever father such beauty, and what womb will bear such light? Wretched fool that I am, who said wicked words to my father. 8 Now let my father give me to Joseph as a maidservant and a slave, and I will serve him forever."

Notes

- a (6:2) Joseph is called a "son of God" as a man close to God. Compare 21:3.

Chapter 7

1 Joseph entered the house of Pentephres and sat on a chair and washed his feet. A table was set for him separately, because he did not eat with the Egyptians; it was an abomination to him. 2 Joseph said to Pentephres and to all his relatives, "Who is that woman standing in the upper room by the window? Let her leave this house." 3 He was afraid she might also pester him, because all the women and daughters of the nobles and satraps of the whole land of Egypt pestered him, wanting to sleep with him. 4 Many Egyptian women and daughters who saw Joseph suffered terribly over his beauty, and they sent their envoys to him with gold and silver and costly gifts. 5 Joseph sent all of it back with threats and insults, saying, "I will not sin before the God of Israel."[a] 6 He kept the face of Jacob,[b] his father, always before his eyes, and he remembered his father's commands.

For Jacob used to say to Joseph and his brothers, “Children, guard yourselves carefully against any foreign woman; do not unite with her, for that is ruin and corruption.” 7 This is why Joseph said, “Let that woman leave this house.” 8 Pentephres said to him, “My lord, the woman you saw in the upper room is not a stranger, but our daughter, a virgin who hates every man. No other man has ever seen her except you, alone, today. 9 If you like, she will come and greet you, for our daughter is your sister.” 10 Joseph was overjoyed, because Pentephres had said, “She is a virgin who hates every man.” 11 Joseph answered Pentephres and his wife, “If she is really your daughter, let her come, for she is my sister, and from today I will love her as my sister.”

Notes

- a (7:5) Hebrew *Yisra’el*, “he strives with God” or “God strives” (Genesis 32:28), the name God gave to Jacob.
- b (7:6) Hebrew *Ya‘aqov*, “he grasps the heel,” and so “he supplants” (Genesis 25:26; 27:36).

Chapter 8

1 Aseneth’s mother went up to the upper floor and brought Aseneth to Joseph. Pentephres said to his daughter Aseneth, “Greet your brother, for he is a virgin as you are today, and he hates every foreign woman as you hate every foreign man.” 2 Aseneth said to Joseph, “Greetings, my lord, blessed by God Most High.”[a] Joseph said to her, “May God, who gives life to everything, bless you.” 3 Pentephres said to Aseneth, “Go to him and kiss your brother.” 4 But when she came forward to kiss Joseph, he stretched out his right hand, laid it against her chest, and said, 5 “It is not fitting for a man who fears God, who blesses the living God with his mouth, eats the blessed bread of life, drinks the blessed cup of immortality, and is anointed with the blessed oil of incorruption, to kiss a foreign woman, one who blesses dead and deaf idols with her mouth, eats the bread of strangling from their table, drinks the cup of ambush from their libation, and is anointed with the oil of destruction. 6 A man who fears God may kiss his mother, and the sister from his own tribe and family, and the wife who shares his bed, all of whom bless the living God with their mouths. 7 In the same way, it is not fitting for a woman who fears God to kiss a foreign

man, because that is an abomination before God." [8] When Aseneth heard Joseph's words, she was deeply grieved. She sighed, staring at Joseph, and her eyes filled with tears. [9] Joseph saw her and felt great pity for her, because Joseph was gentle and merciful and feared the Lord. He raised his right hand over her head and said, [10] "Lord God of my father Israel, Most High, Mighty One, who gives life to all things and called them out of darkness into light, out of error into truth, and out of death into life: you yourself, Lord, give life to this virgin and bless her. [11] Renew her by your Spirit, remold her with your hidden hand, and bring her to life again with your life. Let her eat your bread of life and drink your cup of blessing, she whom you chose before she was born, and let her enter your resting place, which you have prepared for your chosen ones."

Notes

- a (8:2) Greek *Hypsistos*, "Most High," which translates the Hebrew *El Elyon*, "God Most High" (Genesis 14:18–20).

Chapter 9

[1] Aseneth was very happy at Joseph's blessing. She hurried up to her room and collapsed on her couch, sick, for joy, grief, and great fear were all mixed in her, and a steady sweat poured over her at hearing the words Joseph had spoken to her, in the name of the Most High God. [2] She wept bitterly and at length, and she repented of her gods, whom she had worshiped, and waited for evening to come. [3] Meanwhile Joseph ate and drank, and said to his servants, "Harness the horses to the chariot," for he said, "I will go and make the circuit of the whole city and the land." [4] Pentephres said to Joseph, "My lord, please stay the night here today, and go on your way in the morning." [5] Joseph answered, "No, I will leave today, because this is the very day when God began his works, and on the eighth day I will come back to you again and stay here."[a]

Notes

- a (9:5) "The eighth day" is counted from the day of the visit, so that Joseph returns after one full week.

Chapter 10

1 Then Pentephres and his family left for their own estate. 2 Aseneth
was left alone with her virgins. She was despondent and wept until
the sun set. She ate no bread and drank no water, but while everyone
else slept, she alone stayed awake. 3 She opened her door, went down
to the gate, and found the gatekeeper asleep with her children. 4
Aseneth hurried, took down the skin curtain from the door, filled it
with ashes, carried it up to her room, and set it on the floor. 5 She shut
the door securely, laid the iron bar across it, and groaned with loud
lament and weeping. 6 The virgin whom Aseneth loved best of all the
virgins heard her mistress groaning, woke the other virgins, came,
and found the door shut. 7 She listened to the groaning and weeping
of Aseneth and said, "Why are you so downcast, my lady? What is
troubling you? Open to us, and let us see you." 8 Aseneth, shut inside,
said to them, "I have a terrible pain in my head, and I am resting on
my bed. I cannot get up to open to you now, because I am weak in
all my limbs. Go, each of you, to your own room." 9 Then Aseneth got
up, quietly opened the door, and went to her second room, where her
chests of ornaments were. She opened her chest and took out a black,
dark tunic. 10 This was the tunic of her mourning, which she had worn
when her eldest brother died. 11 Aseneth stripped off her royal robe
and dressed in the black one. She undid her golden belt and tied a
rope around herself. She took the tiara off her head, and the diadem,
and the bracelets from her arms. 12 She took all her choice clothing
and threw it out of the window to the poor. 13 She took all her gods,
the gold ones and the silver ones, without number, smashed them to
pieces, and threw them to the poor and needy. 14 Aseneth took her
royal dinner, the fattened animals, the fish, the meats, every sacrifice
to her gods, and the jars of their libation wine, and threw everything
out of the window to the dogs for food. 15 After that she took the ashes
and poured them out on the floor. 16 She took sackcloth, tied it around
her waist, took the net off her hair, scattered ashes over her head,
and fell down on the ashes. 17 She beat her breast over and over with
both hands, and wept bitterly all night with groaning until morning.
18 When she looked in the morning, the ashes under her had turned

to mud from her tears. 19 Aseneth fell on her face on the ashes again
until the sun set. 20 She did this for seven days, tasting nothing at all.

Chapter 11

1 On the eighth day, at dawn, when the birds had begun to chirp and
the dogs to bark at passersby, Aseneth lifted her head a little from
the floor where she lay, for she was paralyzed in her limbs from so
much self-humbling.[a] 2 She turned toward the wall, and sat under the
window that looked east. She rested her head on her chest, wove
her fingers together over her right knee, and kept her mouth shut.
She had not opened it during the seven days and seven nights of her
self-humbling. 3 She spoke in her heart, without opening her mouth:
"What shall I do, wretched as I am? Where shall I go, and with whom
shall I find shelter? Whom shall I speak to, an orphan virgin, desolate,
abandoned by everyone, and hated? 4 Now they all hate me, and even
my father and mother, because I loathed the gods, destroyed them,
and gave them to the poor to be broken up. My father and mother
said, 'Aseneth is not our daughter.' And all my relatives hate me too,
and all people, because I destroyed their gods. 5 I hated every man
who sought me in marriage, and now, in this humiliation, everyone
hates me, and they enjoy my suffering. 6 But the Lord, the God of
mighty Joseph, hates all who worship idols, for he is a jealous and
terrifying God, as I have heard, toward all who worship foreign gods.
That is why he hates me too, because I worshiped dead and deaf idols
and blessed them. 7 Now I have turned away from their sacrifices, and
my mouth has become a stranger to their table. I have no courage to
call on the Lord, the God of heaven, the Most High, the powerful God
of mighty Joseph, because my mouth is polluted with the sacrifices
of the idols. 8 But I have heard many people say that the Hebrews'
God is a true and living God, merciful, compassionate, patient, full
of mercy, and kind. He does not count the sin of a humble person,
and especially of someone who sins in ignorance, and he does not
prosecute lawlessness when a person is in the time of distress. 9 So I
too, humble as I am, will be bold. I will turn to him and take refuge
in him; I will admit all my sins to him and empty out my plea before

him, and he may take pity on my misery. [10] Who knows whether he will see this humiliation of mine and the emptiness of my soul, and feel sorrow for me, and see how wretched and orphaned I am, and my virginity, and shield me? I hear that he is himself a father of orphans, a consolation for the afflicted, and an aid to the persecuted. [11] In any case, humble as I am, I will be bold and cry out to him." [12] Then Aseneth rose from the wall where she sat, knelt, directed her eyes toward heaven, opened her mouth, and said to God:

Notes

- a (11:1) The Greek text here is damaged. Chapter 11 of the CJT follows the sense of the Greek, which has only a few broken lines left ("counting the sin of a humble person," "I will confess all my sins to him"), together with the fuller reading of the Greek tradition as translated by E. W. Brooks in 1918. Verse numbers here are those of this edition.

Chapter 12

[1] She spread out her hands toward the east and lifted her eyes toward heaven, and said: [2] "Lord God of the ages, who gave the breath of life to all, who brought the unseen into the light, who made everything and made the hidden things appear, [3] who raised up the heavens and founded the earth on the waters, who fixed the great stones upon the deep of the water, stones that will never sink but remain until the end, doing your will: [4] Lord my God, I cry out to you. Listen to my plea; I confess my sins to you and uncover my lawless deeds before you. [5] I have sinned, Lord; I have sinned. I have broken your law, been godless, and spoken evil in your presence. My mouth, Lord, has been polluted by the sacrifices to idols and from the table of the gods of the Egyptians. [6] I have sinned, Lord, before you. I have been godless, because I worshiped idols that are dead and deaf, and wretch that I am, I am not fit to open my mouth to you. [7] I have sinned, Lord, before you, I, the daughter of Pentephres the priest, who was proud and arrogant. I bring my plea to you, Lord, and cry out to you. Rescue me from those who pursue me, because I have fled to you like a child to its father and mother. [8] You, Lord, stretch out your hands over me like a father who loves his children, and tenderly, and snatch me from the hand of the enemy. [9] For look, the fierce old lion is chasing me,

and his cubs are the gods of the Egyptians, whom I threw away and destroyed; and their father, the devil, is trying to swallow me. [10] But you, Lord, save me from his hands, and pull me out of his mouth, so that he does not seize me like a wolf and tear me apart and throw me into the abyss of fire, into the storm of the sea, and so that the great sea monster does not swallow me. [11] Save me, Lord, in my desolation, for my father and mother have disowned me because I destroyed and smashed their gods. Now I am an orphan, alone, and I have no hope but you, Lord. For you are the father of orphans, the defender of the persecuted, and the helper of the oppressed. [12] Look, all the wealth of my father Pentephres is temporary and fading, but the dwellings of your inheritance, Lord, are incorruptible and eternal.

Chapter 13

[1] Visit my orphaned state, Lord, because I have fled to you. [2] Look, I have laid aside my royal robe woven with gold, and put on a black tunic. [3] Look, I have loosened my golden belt and tied on a rope and sackcloth. [4] Look, I have thrown the diadem off my head and covered myself with ashes. [5] Look, the floor of my room, which was paved with colored and purple stone and sprinkled with perfumes, is now sprinkled with my tears and covered with dust. [6] Look, my Lord, from the ashes and my tears there is a great deal of mud in my room, as on a wide road. [7] Look, Lord, I have given my royal dinner and the fattened food to the dogs. [8] Look, for seven days and seven nights I have eaten no bread and drunk no water, and my mouth is as dry as a drum, my tongue is like a horn, and my lips like a piece of broken pottery. My face has sunk in, and my eyes have failed from the burning of my tears. [9] But, Lord, forgive me, because I sinned against you in ignorance and spoke blasphemies against my lord Joseph. [10] I did not know, wretch that I am, that he is your son, Lord, because people told me that Joseph was the shepherd's son from the country of Canaan, and I believed them, and I was deceived. I despised your chosen one, Joseph, and spoke evil of him, not knowing that he is your son. [11] What man has ever fathered such beauty, and who else is as wise and strong as Joseph? But, my Lord, I place him in your

care, because I love him more than my own soul. 12 Keep him in the wisdom of your grace, and place me with him as a maidservant, so that I may wash his feet, wait on him, and serve him all the days of my life."

Chapter 14

1 When Aseneth had finished her confession to the Lord, the Morning Star[a] rose in the sky in the east. Aseneth saw it and was glad, and said, 2 "Then the Lord God has heard me, because this star is the messenger and herald of the light of the great day." 3 And look, near the Morning Star the heaven was torn open, and a light appeared that no one can describe. 4 Aseneth fell on her face in the ashes, and a man came to her from heaven. He stood over her head and called her: "Aseneth." 5 She said, "Who is calling me? The door of my room is shut, and the tower is high. How did he get into my room?" 6 The man called her a second time and said, "Aseneth, Aseneth." She said, "Here I am, my lord. Tell me who you are." 7 The man said, "I am the commander of the house of the Lord and chief captain of all the army of the Most High.[b] Stand up on your feet, and I will speak to you." 8 She lifted her eyes and saw a man who was like Joseph in every way, in his robe, his crown, and his royal rod, 9 except that his face was like lightning, his eyes like the shining of the sun, the hair on his head like a flame of fire, and his hands and feet like iron glowing from the fire. 10 Aseneth saw him and fell on her face at his feet in great fear and trembling. 11 The man said to her, "Take heart, Aseneth, and do not be afraid. Stand up on your feet, and I will speak to you." 12 Aseneth stood up, and the man said to her, "Take off the black tunic you are wearing, and the sackcloth from your waist. Shake the ashes off your head and wash your face with living water, 13 and put on a new, untouched robe, and tie around your waist your bright double belt of virginity, 14 and come to me again, and I will tell you the words that have been sent to you." 15 Aseneth went into her room where the chests of her ornaments were, opened her chest, and took out a new, splendid robe. She took off the black one and put on the new, bright one. 16 She untied the rope and the sackcloth from her waist and put on a bright double belt of virginity,

one belt around her waist and one over her chest. 17 She shook the ashes off her head, washed her face with clean water, and covered her head with a fine, splendid veil.

Notes

- a (14:1) Greek *heosphoros*, "dawn-bringer," the planet Venus when it rises before the sun (Hebrew *Helel*, "shining one," in Isaiah 14:12).
- b (14:7) Compare Joshua 5:14–15, where the figure who meets Joshua calls himself the "commander of the army of Yahweh." Jewish tradition identified this figure with the archangel Michael (Hebrew *Mikha'el*, "Who is like God?"), but the Greek text here does not give his name.

Chapter 15

1 She came to the man, and when he saw her he said, "Take the veil off your head, because you are a pure virgin today, and your head is like a young man's." 2 She took it off her head. The man said to her, "Take heart, Aseneth, because the Lord has heard the words of your confession. 3 Take heart, Aseneth. Your name has been recorded in the book of life, and it will not be erased. 4 From today you will be renewed, and formed anew, and brought to life again; you will eat the bread of life, drink the cup of immortality, and be anointed with the oil of incorruption. 5 Take heart, Aseneth. The Lord has given you to Joseph as a bride, and he will be your bridegroom. 6 You will no longer be called Aseneth, but your name will be City of Refuge,[a] because many nations will take refuge in you, many peoples will shelter under your wings, and those who attach themselves to God through repentance will be guarded within your wall. 7 For Repentance is the daughter of the Most High, and she begs the Most High on your behalf at every hour, and on behalf of all who repent, since he is the father of Repentance, and she is the mother of virgins and pleads with him at every hour for those who repent. For he has prepared a heavenly bridal chamber for those who love her, and she will serve them forever. 8 Repentance is a very beautiful virgin, pure, chaste, and gentle. God Most High loves her, and all the angels respect her. 9 Look, I am going to Joseph, and I will speak to him about you, and he will come to you today, and see you, and be glad about you, and be your bridegroom. 10 Now listen to me, Aseneth, and put on your wedding

robe, the old, first robe that is stored in your room, and put on all your choice jewelry, and adorn yourself like a bride, and be ready to meet him. 11 For look, he is coming to you today, and he will see you and be glad." 12 When the man had finished speaking to Aseneth, she was filled with great joy, fell at his feet, and said to him, 13 "Blessed be the Lord God, who sent you to rescue me from the darkness and lead me up to the light, and blessed be his name forever. 14 If I have found favor in your sight, my lord, please sit on the couch a little while, and I will set a table and bread, and you will eat. I will bring you good wine, whose fragrance reaches heaven, and you will drink and go on your way."

Notes

- a (15:6) Greek *polis katafyges*. The Hebrew Bible has "cities of refuge" (Numbers 35:6–15) where those who had killed accidentally could flee. Here the name describes what Aseneth will be for repentant nations.

Chapter 16

1 The man said to her, "Bring me a honeycomb too." 2 Aseneth said, "Lord, I will send to the field of my estate and bring you a honeycomb." 3 The man said to her, "Go into your room, and you will find a honeycomb." 4 Aseneth went into her room and found a honeycomb lying on the table. The comb was white as snow and full of honey, and its aroma was the fragrance of life. 5 Aseneth took the comb and brought it to him. The man said to her, "Why did you say there was no honeycomb in my house? Look, you have brought me one." 6 Aseneth said, "Lord, I had no honeycomb in my house, but it has come to be as you said. Perhaps it came out of your mouth, because its scent is like the scent of perfume." 7 The man stretched out his hand and gripped her head and said, "You are blessed, Aseneth, because the secrets of God have been revealed to you, and blessed are those who attach themselves to the Lord God in repentance, for they will eat from this comb. 8 The bees of the paradise of delight[a] made this honey, and the angels of God eat from it, and whoever eats of it will never die." 9 The man stretched out his right hand, broke off a piece of the comb, ate it, and with his hand put some of the comb into Aseneth's

mouth. [10] He stretched out his hand and laid his finger on the east-facing edge of the comb, and the path of his finger turned to blood. [11] He stretched out his hand a second time, laying his finger on the north-facing edge of the comb, and the path of his finger became like blood. [12] Aseneth stood on his left and watched everything the man did. [13] Bees came up out of the cells of the comb. They were white as snow, with wings like purple, like blue, and like threads of gold, and they had golden crowns on their heads and sharp stings. [14] All the bees swarmed around Aseneth from her feet to her head, and other bees, as large as queens, took hold of her lips. [15] The man said to the bees, "Return now to your places." [16] They all left Aseneth and fell to the ground, all of them, and died. [17] The man said, "Get up now and go to your place." They got up and went away, all of them, to the courtyard next to Aseneth's house.

Notes

- a (16:8) Greek *paradeisos tryphes*, from the Hebrew *Gan Eden*, the "garden of Eden," where *Eden* means "delight."

Chapter 17

[1] The man said to Aseneth, "Have you seen this thing?" She said, "Look, Lord, I have seen all of it." [2] The man said, "So shall the words be that I have spoken to you." [3] The man touched the honeycomb, and fire rose from the table and consumed it. A sweet smell came from the burning comb and filled the room. [4] Aseneth said to the man, "Lord, I have seven virgins with me who wait on me, who grew up with me from my earliest years, born on the same night as I was, and I love them. Let me call them, and bless them as you have blessed me." [5] He said, "Call them." Aseneth called them, and the man blessed them and said, "May God Most High bless you forever." [6] The man said to Aseneth, "Take away this table." Aseneth turned to move the table, and the man vanished from her sight, and Aseneth saw something like a chariot of fire being taken up into heaven toward the east. [7] Aseneth said, "Lord, be gracious to your servant, because I spoke evil in your presence in ignorance."

Chapter 18

1 While these things were happening, a young man from Joseph's household came and said, "Look, Joseph, the mighty one of God, is coming to you today." 2 Aseneth called the steward of her house and said, "Prepare a fine dinner for me, because Joseph, the mighty one of God, is coming to us." 3 Aseneth went into her room, opened her chest, took out her first robe, which looked like lightning, and put it on. 4 She tied on a bright, royal belt, a belt set with costly stones. 5 She put golden bracelets on her arms, golden trousers on her legs, a precious necklace around her neck, and a golden crown on her head, and the crown had costly stones on the front. 6 She covered her head with a veil. 7 She said to her maidservant, "Bring me clean water from the spring." Aseneth bent over the water in the basin, and her face was like the sun, and her eyes like a rising morning star.

Chapter 19

1 A small boy came and said to Aseneth, "Look, Joseph is at the doors of our courtyard." Aseneth went down with the seven virgins to meet him. 2 When Joseph saw her, he said to her, "Come to me, pure virgin, because I received good news about you from heaven, from one who told me everything about you." 3 Joseph stretched out his arms and embraced Aseneth, and Aseneth embraced Joseph, and they kissed each other for a long time, and their spirits were revived.

Chapter 20

1 Aseneth said to him, "Come, my lord, and enter my house." She took his right hand in hers and brought him into her house. 2 Joseph sat on the chair of Pentephres her father, and water was brought to wash his feet. Joseph said to her, "Let one of the virgins come to wash my feet." 3 Aseneth said to him, "No, my lord, because my hands are your hands and your feet are my feet, and no one else will wash your feet." She insisted, and washed his feet. 4 Joseph took her right hand and kissed it, and Aseneth kissed his head. 5 Aseneth's parents came from the field of their estate and saw Aseneth sitting with Joseph, dressed in a wedding robe. They were glad and gave glory to God, and they

ate and drank. 6 Pentephres said to Joseph, "Tomorrow I will invite the nobles and satraps of Egypt, and I will give you a wedding, and you will take Aseneth as your wife." 7 Joseph said, "First I will tell Pharaoh about Aseneth, because he is a father to me, and he will give me Aseneth as my wife." 8 Joseph stayed that day with Pentephres and did not go in to Aseneth, because he said, "It is not right for a man who fears God to sleep with his wife before the wedding."

Chapter 21

1 Joseph got up in the morning and went to Pharaoh and talked to him about Aseneth. 2 Pharaoh sent and called Pentephres and Aseneth. 3 Pharaoh was amazed at her beauty and said, "The Lord, the God of Joseph, will bless you, because he has chosen you to be his bride; for he is the firstborn son of God, and you will be called a daughter of the Most High,[a] and Joseph will be your bridegroom forever." 4 Pharaoh took golden crowns and put them on their heads and said, "May God Most High bless you and multiply you forever." 5 Pharaoh turned them to face each other, and they kissed each other. 6 Pharaoh gave them a wedding, with a banquet and much drinking, for seven days. 7 He called all the rulers of the land of Egypt and had it proclaimed: "Anyone who does any work during the seven days of Joseph and Aseneth's wedding will die a bitter death." 8 When the wedding was over and the banquet finished, Joseph went in to Aseneth, and Aseneth conceived by Joseph. She gave birth to Manasseh[b] and his brother Ephraim[c] in Joseph's house.

Notes

- a (21:3) In some witnesses the words "for he is the firstborn son of God, and" are missing. The Greek text has Pharaoh call Joseph "the firstborn son of God," a title that rests on the idea of Israel as God's firstborn son (Exodus 4:22).
- b (21:8) Hebrew *Menashsheh*, "making to forget" (Genesis 41:51).
- c (21:8) Hebrew *Efrayim*, "doubly fruitful" (Genesis 41:52).

Chapter 22

1 After this, the seven years of plenty passed, and the seven years of famine began. 2 When Jacob heard of his son Joseph, he entered Egypt, together with his whole household, in the second month (April–

May), on the twenty-first day of the month,[a] and settled in the land of Goshen.[b] 3 Aseneth said to Joseph, "I will go and see your father, because your father Israel is a father to me." Joseph said to her, "Let us go together." 4 Joseph and Aseneth came to the land of Goshen, and Joseph's brothers met them and bowed to the ground. 5 They came to Jacob, and he blessed them and kissed them. Aseneth hung on the neck of Jacob, her father-in-law, and kissed him. 6 After this they ate and drank. 7 Joseph and Aseneth went home, and Simeon[c] and Levi[d] escorted them, because their enemies were jealous. Levi walked on the right of Aseneth, and Simeon on her left. 8 Aseneth took Levi's hand, because she loved him as a prophet, a man who reveres God and fears the Lord. 9 He used to see writing in the heavens, and read it and secretly explain it to Aseneth, and Levi saw her place of rest in the heights.

Notes

- a (22:2) The Greek says "the second month, the twenty-first day." The Hebrew months are lunar; see the note on 1:1.
- b (22:2) Hebrew *Goshen*; the name is Egyptian or Semitic, and its meaning is uncertain.
- c (22:7) Hebrew *Shim'on*, "he hears" (Genesis 29:33).
- d (22:7) Hebrew *Levi*, "joined" (Genesis 29:34).

Chapter 23

1 While Joseph and Aseneth were passing by, Pharaoh's eldest son saw them from the wall. 2 When he saw Aseneth, he was driven wild with desire for her because of her extraordinary beauty. Pharaoh's son sent messengers and summoned Simeon and Levi. 3 They came to him and stood before him, and Pharaoh's son said to them, "I know that you are men stronger than any people on earth. By your hands the city of the Shechemites[a] was destroyed, and with your two swords thirty thousand men of war were cut down. 4 I ask you to hurry to my help. Look, I will take you as my companions and give you a great deal of gold and silver, and male and female slaves, and houses and great estates. Help me, and show me kindness, because I have been insulted by your brother Joseph, who has taken Aseneth as his wife, though she was promised to me from the beginning. 5 If you do not listen to

what I say, I will kill you with my sword." As he said this, he drew his sword and showed it to them. 6 Simeon was a bold and daring man. He drew his sword out of its sheath and was ready to strike Pharaoh's son. 7 Levi knew Simeon's thought, because Levi was a prophet and foresaw everything that was to come. He struck Simeon's right foot, pressed it, and signaled him to calm his anger. 8 Levi said to him, "Why are you angry with him? We are the sons of a man who fears God, and it is not right for a man who fears God to repay evil for evil to his neighbor." 9 Levi said to the son of Pharaoh, his neighbor, with a gentle heart and a cheerful face, "Why, my lord, do you say these words in front of us? We are men who fear God, our father is a servant of the God Most High, and our brother Joseph is dear to God. 10 How could we do this evil thing before God? Now listen to us, and take care not to say these words about our brother Joseph again. 11 If you insist on this evil plan, look, our swords are drawn in front of you." 12 They pulled their swords out of their sheaths and said, "Have you seen these swords? With them the Lord God avenged the outrage against the sons of Israel that the Shechemites committed against our sister Dinah,[b] whom Shechem,[c] the son of Hamor,[d] defiled." 13 Pharaoh's son saw their swords drawn and was frightened and shook, and fell on his face on the ground beneath their feet. 14 Levi stretched out his hand and lifted him up, saying, "Do not be afraid, but take care not to say an evil word again against our brother." 15 They left him there, trembling and afraid.

Notes

- a (23:3) *Shechem* is Hebrew for "shoulder," and the town was named for its position on a ridge; the Shechemites are its inhabitants. The story is in Genesis 34.
- b (23:12) Hebrew *Dinah*, "judgment" or "vindicated."
- c (23:12) Hebrew *Shekhem*, "shoulder."
- d (23:12) Hebrew *Hamor*, "donkey."

Chapter 24

1 Pharaoh's son was weighed down and deeply troubled because of Aseneth, and he was sick with it. 2 His servants said in his ear, "Look, the sons of Bilhah[a] and Zilpah,[b] the servant girls of Leah[c] and Rachel, the wives of Jacob, are enemies of Joseph and Aseneth and

are jealous of them, and they will do what you want." 3 Pharaoh's
son sent messengers to summon them, and they came to him by
night. Pharaoh's son said to them, "I know that you are mighty men."
4 Gad and Dan,[d] the older brothers, said to Pharaoh's son, "Let our
lord say to his servants what he wants, and we will do his will." 5
Pharaoh's son was overjoyed, and said to his servants, "Go away from
here, so that I can speak my word to these men in secret." 6 All the
servants left, and Pharaoh's son lied to them: "Blessing and death are
set before you; take the blessing, and not death. 7 Look, I know you
are mighty men. Do not die like women, but act like men and take
revenge on your enemies. 8 I will wait for my father's death, and then
I will crush them and all their family, so that they will not inherit
with us, because they are the children of servant girls, and they are
the ones who sold me to the Ishmaelites.[e] 9 I will repay them for the
evil they did to me, as soon as my father dies." 10 My father Pharaoh
praised Joseph and said to him, "You have spoken well, child. Now
take mighty men from me and go out against them, as they have
dealt with you, and I will be your helper."[f] 11 When the men heard the
words of Pharaoh's son, they were alarmed and distressed, and said
to him, "We beg you, lord, help us, and whatever you command your
servants, we will do." 12 Pharaoh's son said to them, "I will kill my
father tonight, because Pharaoh my father is like a father to Joseph.
Then you must kill Joseph too, and I will take Aseneth as my wife." 13
Dan and Gad said to him, "We will do whatever you command us. We
have heard Joseph telling Aseneth, 'Go tomorrow to the field of our
estate, because it is the time of the grape harvest.' He is giving her
six hundred men who are mighty in war, and fifty runners ahead." 14
When Pharaoh's son heard these words, he gave the four men five
hundred men each, and made them their commanders and leaders. 15
Dan and Gad said to him, "We will go by night and lie in ambush at
the wadi, and hide in the reeds. 16 You take fifty mounted archers with
you and go ahead, keeping at a distance. Aseneth will arrive and drop
into our hands, and we will hack down the men with her. 17 Aseneth
will flee with her carriage and fall into your hands, and you can do
with her whatever your soul desires. 18 After that we will kill Joseph,

grieving for Aseneth, and we will kill his children before his eyes." [19] Pharaoh's son was glad when he heard these words, and sent two thousand fighting men after them. [20] They came to the wadi, hid in the reeds, and five hundred men sat in front, and between them was a broad road.

Notes

- a (24:2) Hebrew *Bilhah*, perhaps "timid" or "bashful."
- b (24:2) Hebrew *Zilpah*; the meaning is uncertain.
- c (24:2) Hebrew *Le'ah*, possibly "wild cow" or "weary."
- d (24:4) Hebrew *Gad*, "fortune"; Hebrew *Dan*, "he judged."
- e (24:8) Hebrew *Yishma'e'l*, "God hears." In Genesis 37, Joseph's brothers sold him to Ishmaelite traders. The prince's words, "sold me," fit awkwardly here, since it was Joseph who was sold.
- f (24:10) This verse is in the Greek text as it stands, but it seems out of place: it has Pharaoh's son speak of his father Pharaoh praising Joseph. The Greek tradition is confused here.

Chapter 25

[1] Pharaoh's son went to his father's chamber to kill him, and his father's guards prevented him from going in. [2] Pharaoh's son said to them, "I will see my father, because I am going to pick the grapes of my new vineyard." [3] The guards said to him, "Your father is in pain, has stayed awake all night, and is resting. He told us, 'Let no one come in to me, not even my firstborn son.'" [4] He left in a rage and took fifty mounted archers and went ahead of them, as Dan and Gad had told him. [5] Naphtali and Asher[a] said to Dan and Gad, "Why are you plotting evil again against our father Israel and our brother Joseph? God protects him as the apple of his eye. [6] Did you not sell him once already, and today he is king of the whole land, a savior, and the one who gives out grain? [7] If you now plot evil against him again, he will call on the God of Israel, who will send fire from heaven to devour you, and God's angels will make war on you." [8] Their older brothers, Dan and Gad, were angry with them and said, "So should we die like women? Never!" And they set out to meet Joseph and Aseneth.

Notes

- a (25:5) Hebrew *Naftali*, "my wrestling" (Genesis 30:8); Hebrew *Asher*, "happy" (Genesis 30:13).

Chapter 26

1 Aseneth got up early and said to Joseph, “I will go to the field of
our estate, but my soul is afraid, because I am being separated from
you.” 2 Joseph said to her, “Take heart and do not be afraid, but go. The
Lord is with you, and he will protect you as the apple of his eye from
every evil. 3 I will go to my grain distribution and give grain to all the
people in the city, so that no one in the land of Egypt dies of hunger.” 4
Aseneth went on her way, and Joseph went to his grain distribution. 5
Aseneth came to the place of the wadi with her six hundred men, and
suddenly Pharaoh’s son and his men sprang out of their ambush and
joined battle with Aseneth’s fighters. They cut them all down with
their swords and killed all of Aseneth’s runners. 6 Aseneth fled in her
carriage. 7 Levi, the son of Leah, knew all this as a prophet, and told
his brothers about the danger Aseneth was in. Each of them took his
sword on his thigh, his shield on his arm, and his spear in his right
hand, and they chased after Aseneth at a fast run. 8 Aseneth fled, and
look, Pharaoh’s son met her, with fifty men. Aseneth saw him, and
she was afraid and trembled.

Chapter 27

1 Benjamin[a] was sitting with her in the carriage. 2 Benjamin was a
strong youth, about eighteen years old, with unspeakable beauty and
the strength of a lion’s cub, and he feared God. 3 Benjamin jumped
down from the carriage, picked up a round stone from the wadi so
that it filled his hand, threw it at Pharaoh’s son, and hit him on
his left temple. He gave him a great and heavy wound, and he fell
from his horse half dead. 4 Benjamin ran up onto a rock and said to
Aseneth’s charioteer, “Give me fifty stones from the wadi.” 5 He gave
him fifty stones. Benjamin threw the stones and killed the fifty men
accompanying Pharaoh’s son, and the stones sank into the temple of
every one of them. 6 Then Leah’s sons Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah,
Issachar, and Zebulun,[b] chased after the men lying in ambush and
fell on them suddenly and cut down the two thousand men; the six
of them killed them. 7 The sons of Bilhah and Zilpah, their brothers,
fled and said, “We are lost because of our brothers, and Pharaoh’s son

has died at Benjamin's hand, and everyone with him has been killed by his hand. Now come, let us kill Aseneth and Benjamin and flee into the reeds." [8] They came with their swords drawn, full of blood. Aseneth saw them and said, "Lord my God, who gave me life from death, who said to me, 'Your soul will live forever,' save me from these men." The Lord God heard her voice, and at once the swords slipped from their hands and fell on the ground and dissolved like ashes.

Notes

- a (27:1) Hebrew *Binyamin*, "son of the right hand" or "son of the south" (Genesis 35:18).
- b (27:6) Hebrew *Re'uven*, "see, a son"; *Yehudah*, "praise"; *Yissakhar*, "there is reward"; *Zevulun*, "dwelling" (Genesis 29–30).

Chapter 28

[1] The sons of Bilhah and Zilpah saw the wonder that had happened, and were afraid, and said, "The Lord is fighting against us on behalf of Aseneth." [2] They fell on their faces on the ground and bowed to Aseneth, saying, "Have mercy on us, your servants, for you are our mistress and queen, and we have done wicked things against you and against our brother Joseph. [3] Now God has repaid us. That is why we, your servants, beg you: have mercy on us and rescue us from the hands of our brothers, because they are the avengers of the insult to you, and their swords are in front of us." [4] Aseneth said to them, "Take heart and do not be afraid, because your brothers are men who fear God and do not repay evil for evil to anyone. [5] Go into the reeds, until I make peace with them on your behalf and calm their anger, because what you dared to do against them was great. [6] Take heart and do not be afraid, because the Lord will judge between me and you." [7] Dan and Gad fled into the reeds. [8] And look, Leah's sons came running after them like deer. Aseneth got down from her carriage and greeted them with tears. [9] They bowed to the ground before her and wept loudly, and they were looking for their brothers, the sons of the servant girls, to kill them. [10] Aseneth said to them, "Spare your brothers and do not do them harm, because the Lord shielded me and turned their swords to ashes in their hands, and they became like wax before fire. [11] This is enough for us, that the Lord fights for

us. Now spare your brothers." 12 Simeon said to Aseneth, "Why does
our mistress speak this way about her enemies? 13 No, we will cut
them down with our swords, because they plotted evil against our
father Israel and against our brother Joseph, already twice now, and
against you today." 14 Aseneth said to him, "Never, brother. You must
not repay evil for evil to your neighbor, because the Lord will punish
this outrage." 15 After this Simeon embraced Aseneth. Levi came to
her and kissed her right hand and blessed her. 16 So Aseneth saved the
men from their brothers' anger, so that they did not kill them.

Chapter 29

1 Pharaoh's son rose from the ground, sat up, and spat blood out of
his mouth, because blood from his temple had run into his mouth. 2
Benjamin ran over, seized the prince's sword, and pulled it from its
sheath, because Benjamin was not wearing a sword on his thigh. 3
As he was about to strike Pharaoh's son, Levi ran and held his hand,
and said, "Never, brother, do this deed, because we are men who fear
God, and it is not right for a man who fears God to repay evil for evil,
or to trample a man who has fallen, or to crush an enemy to death.
4 Come, let us treat him for his wound, and if he lives, he will be a
friend to us, and Pharaoh his father will be a father to us." 5 Levi lifted
Pharaoh's son up, washed the blood from his face, bound a bandage
on his wound, set him on his horse, and brought him to his father. 6
Levi told him everything that had happened. 7 Pharaoh got up from
his throne and bowed to the ground before Levi. 8 On the third day
Pharaoh's son died of the wound from Benjamin's stone. 9 Pharaoh
mourned for his firstborn son, and from grief he fell ill. 10 Pharaoh
died at the age of one hundred and nine, and he left his diadem to
Joseph. 11 Joseph reigned in Egypt for forty-eight years, and after that
Joseph gave the diadem to Pharaoh's grandson. And Joseph was like
a father to him in Egypt.

Apocalypse of Abraham

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

The Book of the Revelation of Abraham, son of Terah, son of Nahor, son of Serug, son of Reu, son of Arphaxad, son of Shem, son of Noah, son of Lamech, son of Methuselah, son of Enoch, son of Jared.

1 On the day that I planed smooth the gods of my father Terah, and those of his brother Nahor, I was searching to learn who the Mighty God truly is. 2 I, Abraham,[l] had been given my turn at the work, and I had finished the sacrifices my father Terah offered to his gods of wood and stone, of gold and silver, of bronze and iron. 3 I went into their temple to serve, and I found the god named Merumath,[m] a carved stone figure, which had toppled onto its face before the iron god Nahon.[n] 4 When I saw it, my heart was troubled. I thought that I, Abraham, could not put it back in its place alone, because it was heavy, being a big stone. 5 I went out and told my father, and he came in with me. The two of us pushed the god upright to set it back, and its head fell off while I was still holding it by the head. 6 When my father saw Merumath's head in my hands, detached from the body, he called, "Abraham!" "I am here," I answered. 7 He said, "Bring me one of the small axes from the house." I brought it to him. 8 Then he hewed another Merumath out of another stone, with no head. He took the head that had fallen from the first Merumath and set it on the new body, and he smashed the rest of the first one to pieces.

Notes

- a (1:title) Hebrew *Terach*; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (1:title) Hebrew *Nachor*, "snorting" or "snoring."
- c (1:title) Hebrew *Serug*, "branch" or "tendril" (uncertain).
- d (1:title) Hebrew *Re'u*, "friend." The Slavonic text has "Roog," an old form of the name.
- e (1:title) Hebrew *Arpakshad*; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (1:title) Hebrew *Shem*, "name."

- g (1:title) Hebrew *Noach*, “rest.”
- h (1:title) Hebrew *Lemech*; the meaning is uncertain.
- i (1:title) Hebrew *Metushelach*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps “man of the javelin.”
- j (1:title) Hebrew *Chanoch*, “dedicated” or “initiated.”
- k (1:title) Hebrew *Yered*, “descent.” The Slavonic text has “Tared” (or “Arad”). The list leaves out several names found in Genesis 11:10–16 (Peleg, Eber, Shelah), so it is shorter than the Bible’s.
- l (1:2) Hebrew *Avraham*, “father of a multitude” (Genesis 17:5). He was first called Abram, “exalted father.”
- m (1:3) In the Slavonic text the name is *Merumath*. Editors suggest it comes from a Hebrew phrase meaning “stone of deceit.” The statue is stone, and the story mocks it.
- n (1:3) The name is *Nahon* or *Naritson* in different manuscripts. Its meaning is unknown.

Chapter 2

1 Next he fashioned five more gods and handed them to me, telling
me to sell them out in the town’s main street. 2 I loaded my father’s
donkey, put the gods on it, and went toward the inn to sell them. 3
Merchants from Fandana[a] in Syria[b] were passing with camels on their
way to Egypt[c] to trade. I talked with them. 4 One of their camels let out
a groan, and the donkey was frightened and bolted and knocked the
gods off. Three of them were smashed, and two came through whole.
5 The Syrians noticed that I had gods and asked, “Why did you keep
quiet about them? We would have bought them before your donkey
heard the camel and they were lost. At least sell us the ones that are
left, and we will pay a fair price for the smashed ones as well as for
those that survived.” 6 I was worried in my heart about how I could
take the price home to my father. The three broken ones I threw into
the water of the river Gur,[d] which was at that place. They sank into
the depths, and nothing more was seen of them.

Notes

- a (2:3) The place may be Paddan-Aram, “road of Aram” (Genesis 25:20), in northern Mesopotamia. The Slavonic reads *Fandana*.
- b (2:3) Greek *Syria*, from an old name whose meaning is uncertain; the Hebrew is *Aram*.
- c (2:3) Hebrew *Mitsrayim*; the meaning of the name is unknown.

- d (2:6) The river is called *Gur* in the text. Its meaning is uncertain; the Hebrew word *gur* means “cub” or “sojourning.” A later version has the Dead Sea here.

Chapter 3

1 While I was still on the road, my heart was troubled within me
and my mind was distracted. 2 I said in my heart, “What wrong is
my father committing? Is he not the god of his own gods, since
they come into being by his chisels, his lathe, and his skill? Would
it not be more fitting for them to worship him, because they are his
handiwork? What is this folly of my father in the things he makes?
3 “Look, Merumath fell down in his own temple and could not rise. I
was unable to lift him alone; only when my father came could the two
of us stand him up. Even then, weak as we both are, his head came
off, and my father fixed it onto a different stone, the body of another
god he had made headless. 4 “And the other five gods were smashed
to pieces by the donkey. They could not help themselves, and they
could not harm the donkey that broke them. Their fragments did not
come up out of the river either.” 5 I said in my heart, “If that is so, how
can my father’s god Merumath, wearing the head of another stone
and himself made from a third, save anyone, or listen to a person’s
prayer and reward him?”

Chapter 4

1 While I was thinking this over, I reached my father’s house. I gave
the donkey water and hay, then brought the silver and placed it in my
father Terah’s hand. 2 When he saw it he was glad. He said, “Abraham,
my gods have blessed you, because you brought back the price of the
gods, and so my labor was not wasted.” 3 I answered him, “Listen, my
father Terah! Blessed are your gods, because you are their god, since
you made them. Their blessing is ruin and their power is empty. They
could not help themselves, so how can they help you or bless me? 4
“I have been good to you in this affair, because I used my wits and
brought you the money for the broken gods.” 5 When he heard this he
flew into a rage at me, because I had spoken harshly against his gods.

Chapter 5

1 I thought over my father's anger and went out. After I had gone
out, my father called, "Abraham!" I said, "Here I am." 2 He said, "Take
the wood chips from the gods I made out of pine before you came,
gather them up, and get my midday meal ready." 3 As I gathered the
chips I found under them a little god lying among the brushwood to
my left. On its forehead was written, "God Barisat."[a] 4 I said nothing
to my father about the wooden god Barisat I had found beneath the
chips. 5 I laid the chips on the fire to prepare my father's food. I went
out to ask something about the meal, and I set Barisat in front of the
kindled fire. I warned him, "Barisat, take good care that the fire does
not die down before I come back. If it does, blow on it so that it burns
up again." 6 I went out and did what I had to do. When I came back,
I found Barisat fallen on his back, with his feet surrounded by fire
and badly scorched. 7 I burst out laughing and said to myself, "Truly,
Barisat, you can kindle fire and cook food!" 8 While I was speaking,
laughing, he was slowly burned up by the fire and turned to ashes.
9 I carried the meal to my father, and he ate. When I gave him wine
and milk, he grew cheerful and blessed his god Merumath. 10 I said
to him, "Father Terah, do not bless your god Merumath, and do not
praise him. Praise your god Barisat instead, because he loved you
more, and threw himself into the fire to cook your food." 11 He said to
me, "Where is he now?" I said, "He is burnt to ashes in the force of
the fire and turned to dust." 12 He said, "Barisat's power is great! I will
make another one today, and tomorrow he will prepare my meal."

Notes

- a (5:3) The name is *Barisat*. Editors think it may come from the Aramaic *bar ishta*, "son of the fire," which fits the story.

Chapter 6

1 When I, Abraham, heard my father speak like this, I laughed
inwardly, and I sighed with sorrow and anger in my soul. 2 I said to
myself, "How can these manufactured statues, his own handiwork,
help my father? Is it right that the body should serve its soul, and the
soul the spirit, and the spirit folly and ignorance? 3 "Just this once it

is right to endure some trouble. I will set my mind on what is pure and lay my thoughts out plainly before him." 4 I answered, "Father Terah, whichever of these you praise as a god, you are foolish in your mind. 5 "Look at the gods of your brother Haran,[a] who stand in the holy temple. They are worth more honor than yours. 6 "Look at Zucheus,[b] the god of your brother, which is worth more honor than your god Merumath, because he is cast of gold, a metal that people prize. When he wears out he can be melted down and recast. But if your god Merumath is altered or smashed, he cannot be made new, because he is stone. It is the same with the god Joavon,[c] who stands beside Zucheus over the other gods. 7 "How much more honor he deserves than Barisat, a god made of wood, when Joavon is wrought of silver! Look how he has been made valuable to look at by human skill. But your god Barisat, before he was prepared, stood rooted on the earth, great and wonderful with the glory of his branches and blossoms. You chopped him with an axe, and by your craft he was turned into a god. And look, his sap is already dried up and gone, he has dropped from his height to the ground, he has gone from a great state to a small one, and the look of his face has vanished. 8 "Barisat himself has been burned by fire and turned to ashes, and is no more. And you say, 'Today I will make another, and tomorrow he will make my food!' He has perished completely!"

Notes

- a (6:5) The Slavonic text calls him *Oron* or *Zaron*; this is Haran, Abraham's brother (Genesis 11:27). The Hebrew name *Haran* may mean "mountaineer." His name is spelled in different ways in the manuscripts.
- b (6:6) The name is *Zucheus* in the text; its meaning is not known.
- c (6:6) The name is *Joavon* or *Joauv* in different manuscripts. Its meaning is unknown.

Chapter 7

1 "Look, the fire is worth more honor than all the things that are made, because even things that serve nothing else are forced to serve it, and things that are easily destroyed are mocked by its flames. 2 "But the water is worth even more honor, because it overcomes the fire and gives the earth its fill. Even so, I do not call it a god, because it

is subject to the earth, down toward which water leans. [3] "I call the earth worth much more honor, because it overpowers the water and its fullness. Even the earth I do not call a god, because it too is dried out by the sun and is given to people to be plowed. [4] "I call the sun worth more honor than the earth, because its rays light up the whole world and the different regions of the air. Even the sun I do not call a god, because night hides it, and so do clouds that cover its path. [5] "I do not call the moon or the stars gods either, because they too hide their light at night when their time comes. [6] "Listen, Terah, my father! I will tell you who is the God who made everything, and not these things that we regard as gods. Who is he, then, and what is he? He is the one who has made the heavens red and the sun golden, [7] "who has made the moon bright and the stars with it, who has made the dry land in the midst of many waters, and who has set you among the ..."[a] [8] "Yet may God make himself known to us by his own act!"

Notes

- a (7:7) A line is missing or damaged here in the Slavonic text. Some manuscripts add words about Abraham's own thoughts being tested.

Chapter 8

[1] While I was talking this way with my father Terah in the courtyard of my house, the voice of a Mighty One came down from heaven out of a cloud bursting with fire, and it cried out, "Abraham, Abraham!" [2] I said, "Here I am." He said, "You are seeking, with the understanding of your heart, the God of gods, the Creator. I am he. [3] "Go out from your father Terah, and get out of the house, so that you too are not killed in the sins of your father's house." [4] I left. I had not yet passed the courtyard door when a peal of great thunder burned him up, along with his house and everything in it, right down to the ground, for a distance of sixty feet.[a]

Notes

- a (8:4) The Slavonic text says "forty cubits" (a cubit is about 18 inches, so about 60 feet or 18 meters). Late tradition reads the "Ur" of "Ur of the Chaldeans" as "fire," so Abraham was brought out of the fire.

Chapter 9

1 Then a voice called to me a second time: “Abraham, Abraham!” I
answered, “I am here.” 2 He said, “Look, it is I. Do not be afraid, for
I was there before the ages. I am a mighty God, who made the light
of the world. 3 “I am a shield over you, and I am your helper. Go and
fetch for me a heifer, a she-goat, and a ram, each of them three years
of age, with a turtledove and a pigeon, and present me with a clean
sacrifice. 4 “In this sacrifice I will lay out the ages before you and make
known to you what is held in reserve, and you will see great things
that you have not seen before, because you have loved seeking me
out, and I have named you my Friend. 5 “But for forty days keep away
from every kind of food that comes from the fire, and from drinking
wine, and from anointing yourself with oil. Then set out for me the
sacrifice I have commanded, in the place that I will show you, on a
high mountain. 6 “There I will show you the ages that were created
and set in place, made and renewed through my Word, and I will tell
you what will happen in them to those who have done evil and to
those who have lived righteously among the human race.”

Chapter 10

1 When I heard the voice of the one who spoke these words to me,
I looked around, and look, there was not a living soul in sight. My
spirit was terrified; my soul seemed to flee from me. I turned as stiff as
stone and dropped to the ground, for I had no strength left to stand on
the earth. 2 As I lay there still facedown, I heard the Holy One’s voice
saying, “Go, Jaoel,[a] and by my unspeakable Name raise up that man
for me and strengthen him so that he recovers from his trembling.” 3
The angel whom he had sent to me came in the likeness of a man. He
took me by my right hand and stood me on my feet, and said to me,
“Stand up, Abraham, Friend of God who loves you. Do not let human
trembling seize you. Look, I have been sent to you to strengthen you
and bless you in the name of God, who loves you, the Creator of the
heavenly and earthly things. Do not be afraid, and hurry to him. 4
“I am called Jaoel by the one who moves what exists together with
me on the seventh expanse above the firmament. I have the power of

the unspeakable Name that dwells in me. [5] "By his command I have been given charge to restrain the threatening attacks that the living creatures of the Cherubim[b] make on one another, and to teach those who bear him the song of the seventh night-hour of humankind. [6] "I am ordained to hold back Leviathan,[c] because the attack and threat of every kind of snake and crawling thing are subject to me. [7] "I was the one commissioned to set your father's house ablaze with him inside it, because he revered dead idols. [8] "I have been sent to bless you now, and the land that the Eternal One, whom you have called on, has prepared for you, and I have made my way across the earth for your sake. [9] "Stand up, Abraham! Go without fear. Be very glad and rejoice, for I am with you. Eternal honor has been prepared for you by the Eternal One. Go, and carry out the sacrifices that were commanded. [10] "Look, I have been appointed to be with you, and with the generation that is destined to spring from you; and Michael, together with me,[d] blesses you forever. Take heart and go!"

Notes

- a (10:2) The Slavonic text spells the angel's name in several ways. It is the Hebrew *Yahoel*, "Yah is God," and it contains a shortened form of the name Yahweh. In the book the angel carries the power of God's unspeakable Name. In chapter 17 God himself is addressed by this name.
- b (10:5) Hebrew *kerubim*, winged guardian beings that carry or guard the throne of God (Ezekiel 10; Genesis 3:24). The meaning of the word is uncertain.
- c (10:6) Hebrew *Livyatan*, "coiled one," the great sea monster (Job 41; Isaiah 27:1).
- d (10:10) Hebrew *Mikha'el*, "Who is like God?"

Chapter 11

[1] I got up and saw the one who had taken my right hand and set me on my feet. His body looked like sapphire and his face like chrysolite, while the hair on his head was like snow. The turban on his head looked like a rainbow, and his clothing was like purple. A golden scepter was in his right hand. [2] He called, "Abraham!" I answered, "Here I am, your servant." He said, "Do not let my appearance alarm you, or my words, lest your soul be shaken. Come along with me, and I will walk with you until the sacrifice is finished, in a form you

can see; after the sacrifice I will be invisible forever. Take heart, and come!"

Chapter 12

1 The two of us walked on together for forty days and nights. I took
no bread and no water, for the sight of the angel beside me was my
food, and his speech was my drink. 2 We came to the mountain of
God, glorious Horeb.[a] I said to the angel, "O singer of the Eternal
One, look, I have no sacrifice with me, and I know of no place for an
altar on this mountain. How can I make an offering?" 3 He said to me,
"Look around." I looked around, and look, all the animals prescribed
for the sacrifice were following us: the heifer, the female goat, the
ram, the turtledove, and the pigeon. 4 The angel called, "Abraham!"
"Here I am," I replied. He said, "Slaughter all of these. Cut the animals
in two, setting each half opposite the other, but do not cut the birds in
pieces. 5 "Hand the pieces to the men I will show you standing beside
you, for they are the altar on this mountain, to present a sacrifice to
the Eternal One. But give the turtledove and the pigeon to me, for I
will ascend on the wings of the birds, to show you heaven, and the
earth, and the sea, and the abyss, and the underworld, and the Garden
of Eden,[b] and its rivers, and the fullness of the whole world and its
circle. You will look into all of it."

Notes

- a (12:2) Hebrew *Chorev*, "dry" or "desolate"; it is the mountain also called Sinai (Exodus 3:1).
- b (12:5) Hebrew *'Eden*, "delight" (Genesis 2:8).

Chapter 13

1 I did everything as the angel commanded. I gave the divided animals
to the angels who had come to us, but the angel took the birds. I
waited for the evening sacrifice. 2 An unclean bird flew down onto the
carcasses, and I drove it away. The unclean bird spoke to me and said,
"What are you doing, Abraham, on the holy heights, where no one
eats or drinks and there is no human food? These beings consume
everything with fire, and they will burn you up. Leave the man who
is with you and run away, for if you go up to the heights they will

destroy you." [3] When I saw the bird speak, I asked the angel, "What is this, my lord?" He answered, "This is ungodliness; this is Azazel."[a] [4] He said to the bird, "Disgrace on you, Azazel! Abraham's lot is in heaven, but yours is on the earth. You chose and loved this place as the dwelling for your uncleanness, so the eternal Mighty Lord made you a dweller on the earth. [5] "Through you every evil spirit of lies has its being, and through you come wrath and trials on the generations of the ungodly. For God, the Eternal Mighty One, has not allowed the bodies of the righteous to fall into your hand, so that by this means the life of the righteous and the ruin of the unclean may be made certain. [6] "Listen, friend, and go away from me in shame! It has not been given to you to tempt all the righteous. Leave this man! You cannot lead him astray, for he is your enemy, and the enemy of all who follow you and love what you desire. [7] "Look, the robe that once was yours in heaven is set aside for him, and the mortality that was his has passed to you."

Notes

- a (13:3) Hebrew *'Aza'zel*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "God strengthens" or "the rugged mountain." It is the name of the desert demon to whom the scapegoat was sent in Leviticus 16. In the Enoch tradition, Azazel is the chief of the fallen angels.

Chapter 14

[1] The angel called, "Abraham!" I answered, "Here I am, your servant." He said, "From this moment know that the Eternal One, whom you love, has chosen you. Take courage, and use this authority, as far as I direct you, against the one who slanders the truth. [2] "Should I not be able to put to shame the one who has scattered the secrets of heaven over the earth and rebelled against the Mighty One? [3] "Say to him, 'You are the burning coal in the earth's furnace! Go, Azazel, into the trackless parts of the earth. [4] "'Your inheritance lies with those who exist beside you, born with the stars and the clouds, the people whose portion you are, who live through your being. Your enmity is their justification. So, because of your ruin, keep away from me.'" [5] I spoke the words that the angel had taught me. He said, "Abraham!" I said, "Here I am, your servant." [6] The angel said to me, "Do not answer him,

for God has given him power over those who do answer him." [7] The angel spoke to me a second time and said, "Whatever he says to you, do not answer him, so that his will has no way in you, because the Eternal Mighty One has given him weight and will. Do not answer him." I did what the angel commanded me, and however much he spoke to me, I answered him nothing at all.

Chapter 15

[1] When the sun went down, look, there was smoke like the smoke of a furnace. The angels who held the portions of the sacrifice went up from the top of the smoking furnace. [2] The angel took me by the right hand and seated me on the pigeon's right wing, and he took his own place on the turtledove's left wing, birds that had been neither slaughtered nor divided. He carried me to the edges of the flaming fire, and we rose as with many winds to the heaven fixed above the surface. I saw in the air on the height where we had risen a strong light that I cannot describe. [3] And look, in this light there was a fiercely burning fire, and in it many people of male appearance, all changing in look and shape, running and being transformed, and worshiping and crying out in a sound of words that I did not know.

Chapter 16

[1] I said to the angel, "Why have you brought me up here now? I cannot see any longer, because I have already grown weak and my spirit is leaving me." [2] He said to me, "Stay near me; do not be afraid. The one whom you see coming straight toward us with a great voice of holiness is the Eternal One who loves you. But you cannot see him yourself. [3] "Do not let your spirit grow faint because of the loud crying, for I am with you, strengthening you."

Chapter 17

[1] He was still speaking when fire rushed toward us from every side, and inside the fire was a sound like the rushing of great waters, like the surge of the sea in a storm. [2] The angel bent his head and worshiped with me. I wanted to throw myself to the earth, but the high place where we stood now rose straight up and now rolled

downward. [3] He said, "Only worship, Abraham, and sing the song I taught you." There was no ground to fall upon, so I simply worshiped and sang the song he had taught me. [4] "Say it without pausing," he told me. I sang, and he sang the song along with me:

[5] Eternal, powerful, Holy God,[a]
the only God, Most High!
You who are self-existent, who do not decay, who bear no stain,
unmade, spotless, deathless,
lacking nothing, shining by your own light,
with no father and no mother, never born,
lofty One of fire,
friend of humankind, gracious, bountiful,
jealous for me and full of compassion.
[6] Eli,[b] that is, My God,
eternal, strong, holy Sabaoth,[c]
most glorious. God, God, God, God, Jaoel![d]
[7] You are the one my soul has loved!
Everlasting guardian, blazing like flame,
whose voice rolls like thunder,
whose gaze flashes like lightning, who sees everything,
who hears the prayers of those who honor you.
[8] You turn from the pleas of those who burden you with the weight of their offenses.
You untangle the tumults of the world that rise from the wicked and the just in this perishing age,
and you make the age of the righteous new.
[9] You, O Light, shone before the morning light upon your creatures,
and so day came upon the earth.
In your heavenly dwellings no other light is needed,
only the unspeakable radiance from the lamps of your face.
[10] Receive my prayer and take pleasure in it,
and the sacrifice too, which you prepared for yourself through me, your seeker.
Receive me with favor, and show me, and teach me,
and tell your servant what you have promised me.

Notes

- a (17:5) The Slavonic text has *El*, the Hebrew word for "God." It is the short form of *Elohim*, and means "power."
- b (17:6) Hebrew *Eli*, "my God." The Slavonic text explains it itself: "that is, My God."
- c (17:6) Hebrew *Tseva'ot*, "hosts" or "armies." The title "Yahweh of hosts" is common in the Bible; here it stands alone as a name of God.
- d (17:6) The four-fold *El* looks like a stand-in for the four letters of the name Yahweh. *Jaoel* is the name given in chapter 10 to the angel; here God himself is called by it.

Chapter 18

1 I was still singing when the mouth of the fire on the surface leaped upward. I heard a voice like the roar of the sea, and the great quantity of fire could not quiet it. 2 As the fire lifted into the height, I saw beneath it a throne of fire, and around the throne the all-seeing ones, singing the song. Under the throne I saw four living creatures of fire, singing. They shared one appearance, though each had four faces. 3 Their faces looked like this: a lion, a man, an ox, and an eagle. Each body carried four heads, making sixteen faces for the four creatures between them. Every one had six wings, growing from the shoulders, the sides, and the hips. 4 With the pair of wings at their shoulders they covered their faces, with the pair at their hips they covered their feet, and the middle pair they spread out to fly straight ahead. When their singing was done, they looked at one another and glared. 5 The angel who was with me saw them glaring at each other. He left my side and ran to them. He turned each creature's face away from the one that stood opposite, so that they would not see one another's menacing looks. Then he taught them the song of peace, whose source is the Eternal One. 6 I stood alone and watched. Behind the living creatures I saw a chariot with wheels of fire, every wheel full of eyes all around its rim. Above the wheels stood a throne wrapped in fire, and fire circled it. 7 Look, a fire beyond description surrounded a host of flame. I heard its holy voice, which sounded like the voice of a man.

Chapter 19

1 A voice spoke to me from the midst of the fire: “Abraham, Abraham!”
“Here I am,” I answered. 2 He said, “Consider the expanses below
the firmament where you now stand, and see that on none of them
is there anyone but the one you have sought and who has loved
you.” 3 As he spoke, look, the expanses opened, and the heavens lay
under me. On the seventh firmament, where I stood, I saw a widely
spreading fire, and light, and dew, and a crowd of angels, and a power
of unseen glory above the living creatures I had seen. No other being
was there. 4 I looked down from the mountain to the sixth firmament
and saw a throng of angels made of spirit alone, bodiless, who carried
out the orders of the fiery angels on the seventh firmament,[a] while
I stood hanging above them. 5 Look, this firmament held no other
powers of any different form, only spirit-angels, like the power I had
seen on the seventh. He ordered the sixth firmament to be taken
away. 6 Then, on the fifth firmament, I saw the powers of the stars,
who do the tasks assigned to them, and the earth’s elements obeyed
them.

Notes

- a (19:4) The printed Slavonic text has “eighth,” which the editor thinks cannot be right and should be “seventh.”

Chapter 20

1 The Eternal Mighty One spoke to me again: “Abraham, Abraham!”
“Here I am,” I answered. 2 He said, “Look down from above at the stars
beneath you. Count them for me, and tell me how many they are.” I
said, “How could I? I am only a man of dust and ashes.” 3 He said to me,
“Like the number of the stars, and like their power, I will make your
seed a nation and a people, kept apart for me in my inheritance, which
I share with Azazel.” 4 I said, “O Eternal Mighty One, let your servant
speak in your presence, and do not let your anger burn against the
one you have chosen. Look, before you brought me up here Azazel
railed at me. How is it that, though he is not now before you, you
have joined yourself to him?”

Chapter 21

[1] He said to me, “Look now at the firmaments beneath your feet, and understand the creation foreshadowed in this expanse, the creatures that live on it, and the age that is made ready to match it.” [2] I looked beneath my feet and saw below me the sixth heaven and everything in it, and then the earth with its fruits, and what moved on it, and its living beings. I saw the strength of its people, the ungodliness of their souls, their righteous acts, and the first beginnings of their works. [3] I saw the regions below, and the ruin found there, and the Abyss with its torments. I saw the sea there with its islands, its monsters and its fish, and Leviathan with his realm, his lair, his caverns, the world resting on him, his motions, and the devastations of the world that he causes. [4] I saw streams there, and the swelling of their waters, and their bends. [5] I saw the Garden of Eden there, and its fruits, the spring of the river that flows from it, its trees in flower, and those who had lived righteously. I saw their food and their happiness. [6] I saw a great crowd there, men, women, and children, one half to the right of the picture and one half to the left.

Chapter 22

[1] I said, “Eternal One, Mighty One, what does this picture of the creatures mean?” He said to me, “This shows my intention for those who exist in the divine counsel of the world. It pleased me, and later I gave them orders through my Word. [2] “Everything I had decided would come to be was laid out ahead of time in this picture, and stood before me before anything was created, just as you have seen.” [3] I said, “O mighty and eternal Lord, who are the people in this picture, here and there?” He said to me, “The ones on the left are the multitude of nations that have lived in the past and will live after you, some marked for judgment and restoration, others for vengeance and destruction at the world’s end. [4] “But the ones on the right of the picture are the people set apart for me out of the nations that belong to Azazel. These are the ones I have ordained to be born from you and to be named my people.

Chapter 23

1 “Now look again in the picture to see who led Eve astray and what
the fruit of the tree is. Then you will know what is coming, and how
it will go for your seed among the nations at the close of the days of
the age. 2 “Whatever you cannot grasp, I will explain to you, for you
please me, and I will tell you what I keep in my heart.” 3 I looked into
the picture, and my gaze ran to the part beside the Garden of Eden.
There I saw a man of great height and awesome breadth, matchless
in appearance, with his arms around a woman, who had the same
look and form as the man. 4 They stood beneath a tree of Eden. Its
fruit resembled a bunch of vine grapes. Behind the tree stood a figure
shaped like a serpent, with hands and feet like a man’s and wings
upon its shoulders, six on one side and six on the other. They were
holding grapes from the tree in their hands, and the pair I had seen
embracing were both eating it. 5 I said, “Who are these who hold
one another, and who is the one between them, and what is the fruit
they are eating, O Mighty Eternal One?” 6 He said, “Here you see the
human world: Adam,[a] and with him their longing on the earth, who
is Eve.[b] The one between them stands for ungodliness, the start of
their journey to ruin, that is, Azazel.” 7 I said, “O Eternal Mighty One,
why did you give him the power to destroy the generation of human
beings through what they do on the earth?” 8 He said to me, “To those
who choose evil (and how I hated it in those who practice it), I gave
him power over them, and that they should love him.” 9 I answered, “O
Eternal Mighty One, why did you will that evil be desired in human
hearts, when you are angry about what you yourself willed, and at
the one who does what is worthless in your plan?”

Notes

- a (23:6) Hebrew *Adam*, “human being,” from *adamah*, “ground” (Genesis 2:7).
- b (23:6) Hebrew *Chavvah*, “living” (Genesis 3:20).

Chapter 24

1 He said to me, “I am angry at the nations because of you, and because
of the people of your family who will be set apart after you. You
can see in the picture the burden of fate that lies on them. I will tell

you what will happen, and how much, in the last days. Now take in everything that is in the picture." 2 I looked and saw what had been set before me in creation: Adam, with Eve beside him, and with them the crafty Adversary; and Cain,[a] who did lawless things through the Adversary; and Abel,[b] who was murdered, and the destruction that the lawless one brought on him. 3 There I also saw Impurity, and those who crave her, and her filth, and their envy, and the fire of their decay in the deepest places of the earth. 4 There I saw Theft, and those who rush to her, and the ordering of their punishment, the judgment of the Great Assize. 5 There I saw naked men standing forehead to forehead, and their disgrace, and the lust they felt for one another, and their penalty. 6 There I saw Desire, holding in her hand the head of lawlessness in all its kinds, with her contempt and her waste, appointed for destruction.

Notes

- a (24:2) Hebrew *Qayin*, "acquired" or "smith" (Genesis 4:1).
- b (24:2) Hebrew *Hevel*, "breath" or "vapor" (Genesis 4:2).

Chapter 25

1 There I saw the image of jealousy, the idol. It looked like carpentry of the kind my father used to make, but its figure was of gleaming bronze. A man stood before it and bowed down to it. In front of him was an altar, and on the altar lay a boy, killed in the idol's presence. 2 I asked him, "What is this idol? And the altar? Who are the ones being sacrificed, and who is doing the sacrificing? And what is that temple I see, so skillfully built, with a beauty like the glory beneath your throne?" 3 He said, "Listen, Abraham. What you see, the temple and the altar and the beauty, is my plan for the priesthood of my glorious Name. In it every prayer of every person finds its home, along with the rise of kings and prophets and every sacrifice I will command to be offered to me by my people who will come from your line. 4 "But the statue you saw is my anger, the anger the people who will come from you stir up in me. And the man you saw killing is the one who inspires murderous sacrifices, which testify to me, from the creation's beginning, of the final judgment."

Chapter 26

1 I said, “O Eternal Mighty One, why did you arrange for it to be this
way, and then announce what you know?” 2 He said to me, “Listen,
Abraham. Understand what I say, and give me your answer to my
question. Why did your father Terah refuse to hear your voice, and
why did he not give up his devilish idolatry until he died, and all his
household with him?” 3 I said, “O Eternal Mighty One, it was only
because he did not wish to listen to me. I, for my part, did not follow
what he did.” 4 He said to me, “Listen, Abraham. Just as your father’s
will is within him, and your will is within you, so too the will of my
purpose is within me, prepared for the days to come, before you know
about them or see with your own eyes what lies ahead in them. Look
in the picture to see what your descendants will be.”

Chapter 27

1 I looked and saw: look, the picture shook, and from its left side
a pagan people came out. They plundered those on the right, men,
women, and children. Some they butchered; others they carried off
for themselves. 2 Look, I saw them rush at them through four gate-
ways, and they set fire to the temple and robbed it of the holy things
inside. 3 I said, “O Eternal One, look, hordes of pagans are plundering
the people who come from me, whom you have accepted. They kill
some and keep others as strangers. They have burned the temple with
fire, and they steal and wreck its beautiful things. O Eternal Mighty
One, if this is how it is, why have you now wounded my heart, and
why must it be so?” 4 He said to me, “Listen, Abraham. What you have
seen will come to pass because of your seed, who make me angry
through the statue you saw and through the killing of humans in the
picture, in their zeal for the temple. It will be just as you saw.” 5 I
said, “O Eternal Mighty One, let the evil deeds done in ungodliness
pass away for now, and show me instead those who obeyed the
commandments, the works of righteousness. For you are able to do
this.” 6 He told me, “The time of the righteous comes to them first
through the holiness that comes from kings and just rulers, whom I
created in the beginning so that rulers might arise from them among

the people. But from these descend people who look after only their own concerns, as I have shown you and you have seen."

Chapter 28

1 I answered, "O Mighty One, made holy by your power, be gracious to my request. It was for this that you brought me up here, so show me. As you have raised me to your height, so tell me, your beloved, as much as I ask: will what I saw come upon them for a long time?" 2 He showed me a great multitude of his people, and said, "Because of them I will be provoked four times over, as you saw, and in those times I will carry out my punishment for their deeds. 3 "But in the fourth exit, lasting a hundred years plus one hour of the age (that hour is itself a hundred years), they will suffer misfortune among the pagans, though for a single hour there will be mercy and honor, as among the pagans."[a]

Notes

- a (28:3) The Slavonic text has "contumely" ("shame"). The editor suggests an ancient scribe misread a Greek word, and that "in mercy and honor" was meant. "One hour of the age" is a hundred years; compare chapters 29 and 30, where the present age is divided into twelve such hours, that is, about twelve hundred years.

Chapter 29

1 I said, "Eternal One, Mighty One, how long is an hour of the age?" 2 He said, "Twelve years[a] I have set for this godless age, to rule among the pagans and within your seed. Until the end of the times it will go as you saw. Calculate, and understand, and study the picture." 3 I looked, and I saw a man coming out from the left side, from among the pagans.[b] Crowds of men, women, and children came out from among the pagans and bowed to him. 4 While I kept watching, many came out from the right side. Some mocked the man, some hit him, and others bowed to him. 5 I saw these others bowing, and Azazel ran up and bowed to him too, and after he had kissed the man's face he turned and stood behind him. 6 I said, "O Eternal Mighty One, who is the man who is mocked and beaten and honored by the pagans, together with Azazel?" 7 He answered, "Listen, Abraham. The man you saw mocked, beaten, and then honored is the relief that the pagans will give to the

people who come from you, in the last days, during this twelfth hour of the godless age. [8] "When my final age reaches its twelfth year I will raise up this man out of your line, whom you saw come out from my people. Everyone will follow him, and those I have called will join him, those who change their minds. [9] "What it means that you saw some come out from the left side of the picture is this: many from the pagans will place their hope in him. And of your seed on the right side, some mocking and striking and others bowing down, many will stumble over him. [10] "But he is putting to the test those of your seed who have bowed to him, in that twelfth hour of the end, to shorten the age of ungodliness. [11] "Before the age of the righteous starts to grow, my judgment will fall on the lawless pagans by the hand of the people from your seed who were set apart for me. In those days I will bring ten plagues upon every creature of the earth, in the form of misfortune and sickness and the groaning of their souls in grief. I will bring this much upon the generations of people who live on it, for the provocation and corruption of its creatures, by which they provoke me. [12] "Then righteous people from your seed will remain, in the number that I alone keep secret, hurrying, in the glory of my Name, toward the place made ready for them, which you saw laid waste in the picture. They will live and be made secure by sacrifices and by gifts of righteousness and of truth, in the age that belongs to the righteous, and they will rejoice in me forever. [13] "They will destroy those who destroyed them and mock those who mocked them. They will spit in the faces of those who slandered them, while I scorn those people, and the righteous will see me full of joy, celebrating with my people and welcoming those who come back to me in repentance. [14] "See, Abraham, what you have seen. Listen to what you have heard. Take in fully what you have learned. Go to your inheritance, and look, I am with you always."

Notes

- a (29:2) The editor suggests that "hours" should be read here for "years," as the age is divided into twelve hours (see 28:3). If "years" is kept, each "year" may stand for a hundred years.
- b (29:3) The passage about the man who is insulted, beaten, and worshiped, which runs on from here, is printed in italics in the English edition on which this trans-

lation is based. Its editor, G. H. Box, considers it a Jewish-Christian addition to the older text and reads the man as Jesus.

Chapter 30

1 He was still speaking when I found myself on the ground. I said,
"Eternal One, Mighty One, I no longer have the glory I had on high,
and what my soul yearned to grasp in my heart, I still cannot grasp."
2 He said to me, "I will tell you what your heart desires, since you
wanted to see the ten plagues that I have prepared for the pagans,
kept ready for the passing of the twelfth hour of the earth. Listen to
what I reveal to you, and so it will come to pass. 3 "The first is the
agony of great distress. The second is the burning of many cities. The
third is the death and plague of livestock. The fourth is famine across
the entire world and among its peoples. The fifth is the killing of its
rulers, by earthquake and by the sword. The sixth is the multiplying
of hail and snow. The seventh: wild animals will be their tomb. The
eighth: famine and plague will take turns destroying them. The ninth:
the sword, and flight in terror. The tenth: thunder, voices, and an
earthquake that destroys."

Chapter 31

1 "Then I will blow the trumpet from the sky and send my Chosen
One, who carries my whole power in himself in a single measure. He
will call together my despised people from among the nations, and I
will burn in fire those who mocked them and who held rule over them
in this age. 2 "Those who have wrapped me in mockery I will hand
over to the scorn of the age to come. I have made them ready as fuel
for the fire of Hades, and for endless wandering to and fro in the air
of the underworld below the earth, their bodies full of worms.[a] 3 "For
through them the righteous will see the justice of the Creator, the
ones who chose to do my will and openly kept my commandments.
They will rejoice with gladness at the fall of those who remain, who
went after idols and their murders. 4 "For they will rot inside the body
of the wicked worm Azazel and be burned by the flame of Azazel's
tongue. I had hoped they would turn to me in repentance, and not

love and praise the foreign god, nor cling to one who was never their allotted lord, but they have abandoned the mighty Lord."

Notes

- a (31:2) From the words "the body filled with worms" to the end of the book, the text is found in two of the Slavonic manuscripts (A and K) but not in manuscript S, the one this edition follows most closely.

Chapter 32

[1] "So listen, Abraham, and see: look, your seventh generation will go out with you into a foreign land, and they will make slaves of them and treat them badly, for what is, so to speak, a single hour of the age of wickedness. But the nation they serve I will judge."[a]

Notes

- a (32:1) Abraham's "seventh generation" counted with Abraham: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Levi, Kohath, Amram, and Moses. One manuscript (K) ends with a further line: Abraham heard the words of the Lord and took them into his heart.

Ascension of Isaiah

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 When Hezekiah had been on the throne twenty-six years,[a] king of
Judah,[b] he summoned his son Manasseh,[c] his only son. 2 He brought
him before the prophet Isaiah[d] the son of Amoz[e] and of Josab[f] the
son of Isaiah, in order to entrust to him the words of righteousness
the king had himself been shown. 3 They concerned the eternal judg-
ments and the torments of Gehenna,[g] the ruler of this world,[h] and his
angels, authorities, and powers, 4 and they also concerned the faith of
the Beloved,[i] which the king had seen for himself while he was ill, in
the fifteenth year he ruled. 5 He handed Manasseh the written words
that Samnas[j] the scribe had written, along with what Isaiah son of
Amoz had given him and the prophets, so that they could copy it and
keep it by him. It was about what the king had seen in his house:
the judgment of the angels, the ruin of this world, the garments of
the saints and how they would come forth, their transformation, and
the Beloved's persecution and ascension. 6 In Hezekiah's twentieth
year Isaiah had seen what this prophecy says, and had given it to his
son Josab. As Hezekiah gave his orders, with Josab son of Isaiah at
his side, 7 Isaiah said to King Hezekiah (and he did not say it with
Manasseh alone there), "By the life of the Lord[k]—whose name has
never been sent into this world—by the life of the Beloved of my Lord,
and by the life of the Spirit who speaks in me: your son Manasseh will
cancel all these commands and words, and at his hands I will depart
through the torture of my body. 8 Sammael[l] Malchira[m] will become
Manasseh's servant and do all that Manasseh desires, and Manasseh
will turn out to be a follower of Beliar[n] instead of me. 9 He will draw
many in Jerusalem[o] and Judea[p] away from the true faith. Beliar will
settle in Manasseh, and through his hands I will be cut in two with a
saw." 10 Hearing these words, Hezekiah wept very bitterly. He ripped

his clothes, poured dirt over his head, and threw himself face down. 11 Isaiah said to him, “Sammael’s scheme for Manasseh is finished; nothing you do will help.” 12 That same day Hezekiah decided in his heart to put his son Manasseh to death. 13 Then Isaiah told Hezekiah, “The Beloved has made your plan useless, and the intention of your heart will not be carried out. For this is the calling I was called to, and I will receive the Beloved’s inheritance.”

Notes

- a (1:1) Hebrew *Hizqiyyahu*, “Yahweh strengthens.” He reigned over Judah in about 715–686 BC.
- b (1:1) Hebrew *Yehudah*, “praise” (Genesis 29:35).
- c (1:1) Hebrew *Menasheh*, “causing to forget” (Genesis 41:51).
- d (1:2) Hebrew *Yeshayahu*, “Yahweh saves.”
- e (1:2) Hebrew *Amots*, “strong.”
- f (1:2) Ethiopic *Jôsâb*, probably the same as Jashub (Hebrew *Yashuv*, “he returns”), the name of one of Isaiah’s sons in Isaiah 7:3.
- g (1:3) Greek *Geenna*, from the Hebrew *Gey Hinnom*, “valley of Hinnom,” a ravine south of Jerusalem that came to be used as a picture of the place of final punishment.
- h (1:3) The book uses “ruler (or prince) of this world” for Beliar, as in 2:4 and 4:2.
- i (1:4) “The Beloved” (Greek *ho agapetos*) is the title the book uses for Jesus as the chosen Son of God. Scholars note that “the Beloved” was already used for Israel and the Messiah in Jewish writings before the Christian era.
- j (1:5) Greek *Somnas*, Hebrew *Shebna* (2 Kings 18:18); the meaning is uncertain.
- k (1:7) The Ethiopic text uses one word for “Lord” throughout, for God and also for the Beloved (Christ). No form of the name Yahweh appears in the book, so “Lord” is kept as the text has it.
- l (1:8) Hebrew *Sammael*, a name of the chief of the evil angels in Jewish tradition, often explained as “poison of God” or “blind god.”
- m (1:8) Ethiopic *Malkira*; the meaning is unknown. It seems to be another name for Sammael here; later forms of it (Belchira, Melchira) are the name of the false prophet in chapters 2 and 3.
- n (1:8) Hebrew *Beliyya‘al*, “worthlessness” (in Greek, Belial).
- o (1:9) Hebrew *Yerushalayim*; the meaning is uncertain, often explained as “foundation of peace.”
- p (1:9) The land of Judah.

Chapter 2

1 After Hezekiah died and Manasseh took the throne, Manasseh did not keep in mind his father’s commands; he forgot them. Sammael

took up residence in him and held on tight. 2 Manasseh gave up serving his father's God and served Satan,[a] with his angels and his powers. 3 He pulled his father's household, which had stood in Hezekiah's presence, away from words of wisdom and from the worship of God. 4 Manasseh turned his heart toward serving Beliar, for the angel of lawlessness who rules this world is Beliar, and his name is Matanbuchus.[b] Beliar relished Jerusalem on Manasseh's account, and he strengthened Manasseh in leading Israel[c] astray, and in the lawlessness spreading all over Jerusalem. 5 Sorcery and magic multiplied, along with fortune-telling, omen-reading, sexual immorality, adultery, and the hounding of the righteous by Manasseh, Belchira,[d] Tobia[e] the Canaanite,[f] John[g] of Anathoth,[h] and Zadok,[i] the chief of the works. 6 His other deeds are recorded in the book about the kings of Judah and Israel. 7 Isaiah son of Amoz watched the lawlessness going on in Jerusalem, the worship of Satan, and his wantonness, and he withdrew from Jerusalem and made his home in Bethlehem[j] of Judah. 8 There too lawlessness was widespread, so he left Bethlehem and lived on a mountain in a remote place. 9 The prophet Micaiah,[k] the elderly Ananias,[l] Joel,[m] Habakkuk,[n] his son Josab, and many other faithful people, who believed that people can ascend into heaven, also moved out and settled on the mountain. 10 All of them wore hair clothing, and all of them were prophets. They had nothing with them and were bare, and they all wailed aloud over Israel's wandering from the right path. 11 They ate only the wild plants they picked in the mountains. They boiled these and lived on them, with the prophet Isaiah, and they spent two years in the mountains and hills. 12 Some time later, while they were in the wilderness, there was a man in Samaria[o] named Belchira, of the family of Zedekiah[p] son of Chenaan.[q] He was a false prophet, and his home was in Bethlehem. Now Hezekiah son of Chanani,[r] the brother of Zedekiah's father, had, in the time of Ahab,[s] king of Israel, taught the 400 prophets of Baal.[t] He himself had struck and scolded the prophet Micaiah son of Amada.[u] 13 Micaiah had been rebuked by Ahab and thrown in prison. He was with the prophet Zedekiah. They stayed with Ahaziah,[v] the son of Ahab, who was king in Samaria. 14 The prophet Elijah[w] of Tebon[x] in

Gilead[y] rebuked Ahaziah and Samaria. He prophesied that Ahaziah would die on his sickbed and that Samaria would be handed over to Leba Nasr,[z] because it had killed the prophets of God. 15 Hearing of this were the false prophets who attended Ahaziah son of Ahab, and their teacher Jalerjas[aa] of Mount Joel[ab]. 16 (He was Zedekiah's brother.) After hearing it, they persuaded Ahaziah, the king of Aguaron,[ac] and killed Micaiah.

Notes

- a (2:2) Hebrew *satan*, "adversary."
- b (2:4) The Ethiopic form is *Matanbûchûs*. The name has been explained as Hebrew *mattan bukhus*, "worthless gift," but this is only a guess.
- c (2:4) Hebrew *Yisra'el*, "he strives with God" (Genesis 32:28).
- d (2:5) A form of the name Malchira (1:8). Its Greek form is *Belchira* or *Melchias*; the meaning is unknown.
- e (2:5) Hebrew *Toviyyah*, "Yahweh is good."
- f (2:5) The Canaanites were the people who lived in the land before Israel; the name *Kena'an* has an uncertain meaning, perhaps "lowland" or "merchant."
- g (2:5) Hebrew *Yohanan*, "Yahweh is gracious."
- h (2:5) Hebrew *Anatot*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "answers" or linked with the goddess Anat.
- i (2:5) Hebrew *Tsadoq*, "righteous."
- j (2:7) Hebrew *Bet Lekhem*, "house of bread."
- k (2:9) Hebrew *Mikhayhu*, "who is like Yahweh?"
- l (2:9) Greek form of Hebrew *Hananyah*, "Yahweh has been gracious."
- m (2:9) Hebrew *Yo'el*, "Yahweh is God."
- n (2:9) Hebrew *Havaqquq*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "embrace."
- o (2:12) Hebrew *Shomron*, "watch-hill"; the city was named for the hill, which King Omri bought from a man named Shemer (1 Kings 16:24).
- p (2:12) Hebrew *Tsidqiyyahu*, "Yahweh is my righteousness."
- q (2:12) Hebrew *Kena'anah* (1 Kings 22:11); the meaning is uncertain.
- r (2:12) Hebrew *Hanani*, "gracious" or "Yahweh has shown me favor." The Ethiopic names this older "Hezekiah" as an uncle of Zedekiah; the text is uncertain here.
- s (2:12) Hebrew *Ah'av*, "father's brother."
- t (2:12) Hebrew *Ba'al*, "lord" or "master," the title of a Canaanite storm god (1 Kings 18:19).
- u (2:12) Ethiopic *Amâdâ*, for Hebrew *Yimlah* (Imlah, 1 Kings 22:8); the meaning of that name is uncertain.
- v (2:13) Hebrew *Ahazyahu*, "Yahweh has taken hold."
- w (2:14) Hebrew *Eliyyahu*, "my God is Yahweh."

- x (2:14) Ethiopic *Têbôn*, probably the town of Tishbe (1 Kings 17:1); the meaning is uncertain.
- y (2:14) Hebrew *Gil'ad*, probably "rugged."
- z (2:14) Ethiopic *Leba Nâsr*, a corrupt form of Shalmaneser (Akkadian *Shulmanu-asharid*, "the god Shulmanu is foremost"), the king of Assyria who attacked Samaria (2 Kings 17:3).
- aa (2:15) The meaning of this name is unknown.
- ab (2:15) The text is uncertain here; the Ethiopic manuscripts and the other versions give different readings.
- ac (2:16) Ethiopic *Aguarôn*, a corrupt form of Gomorrah (Hebrew *Amorah*; the meaning is uncertain). The writer uses "Gomorrah" as a name of contempt for Samaria; see 3:10.

Chapter 3

1 Belchira learned where Isaiah and his fellow prophets were living. He was himself a resident of the Bethlehem area and a supporter of Manasseh. He gave false prophecies in Jerusalem, and many Jerusalemites sided with him. He was a Samaritan. 2 When Alagar Zagar,[a] king of Assyria,[b] came and captured Samaria and carried off the nine and a half tribes as prisoners, he led them to the mountains of the Medes[c] and the rivers of Tazon.[d] 3 While still young, Belchira escaped and reached Jerusalem during the reign of Hezekiah of Judah. He did not walk in the ways of his Samaritan father, since he was afraid of Hezekiah. 4 Under Hezekiah he was caught uttering lawless words in Jerusalem. 5 Hezekiah's servants denounced him, and he fled into the Bethlehem district. And they persuaded . . . 6 Belchira laid charges against Isaiah and his fellow prophets. He said, "Isaiah and those with him prophesy that Jerusalem and the cities of Judah will be laid waste, that the people of Judah and Benjamin[e] will go into captivity, and that you too, my lord the king, will be led off bound with hooks and iron chains." 7 "But they are prophesying falsely against Israel and Judah. 8 Isaiah has said, 'I see more than Moses[f] the prophet.' 9 Moses said, 'No one can see God and live,' yet Isaiah says, 'I have seen God, and look, I am alive.' 10 "So know this, O king, that he is lying. He has also called Jerusalem Sodom,[g] and he has declared that the leaders of Judah and Jerusalem are the people of Gomorrah." He brought many charges against Isaiah and the prophets before Man-

asseh. 11 Meanwhile Beliar lived in Manasseh's heart, and in the hearts of the princes of Judah and Benjamin, the eunuchs, and the king's counselors. 12 Belchira's words pleased Manasseh greatly, and he sent men and seized Isaiah. 13 For Beliar was furious with Isaiah because of his vision, and because Isaiah had exposed Sammael, and because Isaiah had revealed that the Beloved would go out from the seventh heaven. Isaiah had revealed his transformation and descent and the human likeness he would take, the persecution he would suffer, and the tortures with which the children of Israel would torture him. He had foretold the arrival of his twelve disciples and their teaching, and that he would be crucified on a tree before the Sabbath, crucified together with evildoers, and buried in a tomb. 14 He had foretold that the twelve who were with him would stumble because of him, and that guards would watch the tomb. 15 He had also foretold how the angel of the Christian church would come down, the one who is in the heavens and whom the Lord will call in the last days. 16 And on the third day Gabriel,[h] the angel of the Holy Spirit, with Michael,[i] the chief of the holy angels, would open the tomb. 17 The Beloved, sitting on their shoulders, would come out and send out his twelve disciples. 18 They would teach all nations and every language about the resurrection of the Beloved. Those who believed in his cross would be saved, and also in his ascension to the seventh heaven, from which he came. 19 Many who believed in him would speak through the Holy Spirit. 20 And many signs and wonders would be done in those days. 21 Afterward, as his coming drew near, his disciples would abandon the teaching of the twelve apostles, along with their faith, their love, and their purity. 22 There would be much quarreling as his coming drew near. 23 In those days many would be fond of high office although they had no wisdom. 24 There would be many lawless elders and shepherds who treated their own sheep unjustly, and they would plunder them because they had no holy shepherds. 25 Many would trade the honor of the saints' garments for the garments of the greedy. There would be much favoritism in those days, and many who loved the honor of this world. 26 There would be much slander and boasting as the Lord's coming drew near, and the Holy Spirit would leave many. 27

In those days there would not be many prophets or people speaking trustworthy words, except one here and there in different places, [28] because of the spirit of error, immorality, boasting, and greed that would be found among those called servants of that One, and among those who would welcome that One. [29] There would be great hatred between the shepherds and elders. [30] For in the last days there would be great jealousy, and everyone would say whatever seemed right to him. [31] They would cancel the prophecy of the prophets who were before me, and they would cancel these visions of mine too, so as to speak whatever their own hearts urged.

Notes

- a (3:2) Ethiopic *Alagar Zagâr*, a corrupt form of Shalmaneser (see 2:14).
- b (3:2) Hebrew *Ashshur*, named for the city and god Ashur; the meaning is uncertain.
- c (3:2) Hebrew *Madai*; the meaning is unknown.
- d (3:2) Ethiopic *Tâzôn*, the same as Gozan (2 Kings 17:6); the meaning is unknown.
- e (3:6) Hebrew *Binyamin*, "son of the right hand" or "son of the south."
- f (3:8) Hebrew *Mosheh*, which the Bible links with "drawn out" (Exodus 2:10); it is probably an Egyptian word meaning "child."
- g (3:10) Hebrew *Sedom*; the meaning is unknown.
- h (3:16) Hebrew *Gavri'el*, "mighty one of God" or "God is my strong one."
- i (3:16) Hebrew *Mikha'el*, "who is like God?"

Chapter 4

[1] Listen, Hezekiah, and you, Josab my son: these are the days when the world is being brought to its end. [2] When that end has come, Beliar, the great ruler and king of this world, who has governed it from its beginning, will descend from his firmament looking like a man: a lawless king, the killer of his own mother. This same king [3] will persecute the plant that the twelve apostles of the Beloved planted. One of the twelve will be handed over into his hands. [4] This ruler will arrive in the shape of that king, and every power of this world will come with him and obey him in all that he wishes. [5] At his command the sun will rise in the night, and he will bring out the moon at noon.[a] [6] He will carry out in the world whatever he wishes. He will act and talk like the Beloved, and he will announce, "I am

God, and no one existed before me." [7] Everyone on earth will put their faith in him. [8] They will sacrifice to him and serve him, saying, "This is God, and there is no other beside him." [9] Most of those who had united to welcome the Beloved he will draw over to himself. [10] His miraculous power will show itself in every city and district. [11] In every city he will have his image set up in front of him. [12] He will hold power for three years, seven months, and twenty-seven days.[b] [13] Of those who believed in him, a few will remain in those days as his servants; they will run from wilderness to wilderness, awaiting the Beloved's coming. [14] When 1,332 days have passed,[c] the Lord will arrive with his angels and the hosts of the holy ones out of the seventh heaven, in the splendor of that heaven, and he will haul Beliar down into Gehenna, together with his armies. [15] He will give relief to the devout he finds still alive on earth, and the sun will be put to shame, [16] and also to all who, out of faith in him, have cursed Beliar and his kings. The saints will accompany the Lord, wearing the garments that are now kept on high in the seventh heaven. They will come with him, their spirits clothed, and take up their presence in the world. He will give strength to those still living in the body, along with the saints, clothing them in the saints' garments, and the Lord will wait on those who kept watch in this world. [17] Afterward they will turn upward in their garments, and their bodies will be left behind in the world. [18] Then the Beloved's voice will rebuke in anger everything in heaven and on earth: the mountains and hills, the cities, the wilderness and the woods, the angel of the sun and the angel of the moon, and everything through which Beliar appeared and worked openly in this world. A resurrection and a judgment will take place among them in those days, and the Beloved will send fire out from himself to consume all the godless, so that it will be as if they had never been made. [19] The remainder of this vision is written down in the vision of Babylon.[d] [20] The rest of the vision about the Lord is written in the parables, in my words, in the book that I prophesied in public. [21] As for the Beloved's descent into Sheol,[e] you will find it in the passage where the Lord says, "Look, my Son will understand." All of this is written in the Psalms, among the parables of David[f] son of Jesse,[g] in the Proverbs of

his son Solomon,[h] in the sayings of Korah[i] and of Ethan[j] the Israelite, in the words of Asaph,[k] and in the other Psalms that the angel of the Spirit inspired, 22 namely, those with no name attached to them. They are written also in the words of my father Amos[l] and of the prophets Hosea,[m] Micah,[n] Joel, Nahum,[o] Jonah,[p] Obadiah,[q] Habakkuk, Haggai,[r] Zephaniah,[s] Zechariah,[t] and Malachi,[u] and in what Joseph[v] the Just said, and in the sayings of Daniel.[w]

Notes

- a (4:5) Literally "the sixth hour." The Jews counted the hours of daylight from about 6 a.m., so the sixth hour is about noon.
- b (4:12) This adds up to about 1,335 days, the number in Daniel 12:12, and it recalls the "time, times, and half a time" of Daniel 7:25 and Revelation 12:14. The Ethiopic text of the rest of this verse is broken and is not clear in the sources used here. It seems to say that many of the faithful, who had been hoping for the One who was crucified, Jesus the Lord Christ, will be left, after Isaiah has seen him who was crucified and ascended.
- c (4:14) The Ethiopic gives only "three hundred and thirty-two," and the "one thousand" is supplied from the other versions. It is close to the 1,335 days of Daniel 12:12.
- d (4:19) Hebrew *Bavel*, from Akkadian *Bab-ili*, "gate of the god"; Genesis 11:9 links it with the Hebrew word for "confuse." The writing meant is uncertain; it may refer to Isaiah's oracles against Babylon (Isaiah 13–14 and 21) or to a lost work.
- e (4:21) Hebrew *She'ol*, the place of the dead; the meaning is uncertain.
- f (4:21) Hebrew *David*, probably "beloved."
- g (4:21) Hebrew *Yishay*; the meaning is uncertain.
- h (4:21) Hebrew *Shelomoh*, "peaceful."
- i (4:21) Hebrew *Qorach*, perhaps "bald."
- j (4:21) Hebrew *Eytan*, "enduring."
- k (4:21) Hebrew *Asaf*, "he gathers."
- l (4:22) Hebrew *Amos*, "carried" or "borne."
- m (4:22) Hebrew *Hoshea*, "salvation."
- n (4:22) A short form of Micaiah, "who is like Yahweh?"
- o (4:22) Hebrew *Nachum*, "comfort."
- p (4:22) Hebrew *Yonah*, "dove."
- q (4:22) Hebrew *Ovadyah*, "servant of Yahweh."
- r (4:22) Hebrew *Haggai*, "festival."
- s (4:22) Hebrew *Tsefanyah*, "Yahweh has hidden" or "Yahweh has treasured."
- t (4:22) Hebrew *Zekharyah*, "Yahweh remembers."
- u (4:22) Hebrew *Mal'akhi*, "my messenger."
- v (4:22) Hebrew *Yosef*, "may he add" (Genesis 30:24).

- w (4:22) Hebrew *Daniyye'l*, "God is my judge."

Chapter 5

1 Because of these visions Beliar raged against Isaiah. He took up residence in Manasseh's heart, and Manasseh had Isaiah cut in half with a wooden saw. 2 As Isaiah was being sawn, Belchira stood and denounced him, and all the false prophets stood by, laughing and gloating over Isaiah. 3 With the help of Mechembechus,[a] Belchira stood before Isaiah and mocked him. 4 Belchira told Isaiah, "Say this: 'All that I have spoken was a lie, and Manasseh's ways are good and just. 5 The ways of Belchira and his companions are good too.'" 6 He said this to him as the sawing began. 7 But Isaiah was absorbed in a vision from the Lord; his eyes were open, yet he did not see them. 8 Belchira spoke to Isaiah again: "Say what I tell you, and I will change their minds. I will make Manasseh, the leaders of Judah, the people, and all Jerusalem show you respect." 9 Isaiah answered, "As far as I am able to speak, I say: Damned and cursed be you, and all your powers, and all your house. 10 For you cannot take anything from me except the skin of my body." 11 So they seized Isaiah son of Amoz and sawed him in two with a wooden saw. 12 Manasseh, Belchira, the false prophets, the leaders, and all the people stood watching. 13 Before the sawing, Isaiah had said to the prophets who were with him, "Go to the region of Tyre[b] and Sidon,[c] for God has mixed the cup for me alone." 14 While he was being sawn, Isaiah neither shouted nor wept; his lips spoke with the Holy Spirit until he was cut through. 15 Beliar did this to Isaiah through Belchira and Manasseh. For Sammael had been seething against Isaiah ever since the time of Hezekiah, king of Judah, over what Isaiah had seen concerning the Beloved, 16 and over the destruction of Sammael, which Isaiah had seen through the Lord while Manasseh's father Hezekiah was still king. Manasseh acted according to the will of Satan.

Notes

- a (5:3) Ethiopic *Mechembêchûs*, the same figure as Matanbuchus (2:4); the meaning is uncertain.
- b (5:13) Hebrew *Tsor*, "rock."
- c (5:13) Hebrew *Tsidon*; the meaning is uncertain, perhaps "fishing."

Chapter 6

1 In Hezekiah's twentieth year as king of Judah, Isaiah son of Amoz
came from Gilgal[a] to Jerusalem with his son Josab, to see Hezekiah.
2 Isaiah went in and sat on the king's couch. A seat was brought to
him, but he would not sit on it. 3 As Isaiah began to speak words of
faith and truth with the king, all the leaders of Israel were seated,
with the eunuchs and the royal counselors. Forty prophets and sons
of prophets were also there, who had come from the villages, the hill
country, and the lowlands on hearing that Isaiah was coming from
Gilgal to Hezekiah. 4 They had come to greet him and to hear his
words. 5 They wanted him to lay his hands on them so that they would
prophesy, and so that he could hear their prophecy. They all stood
before Isaiah. 6 While Isaiah was telling Hezekiah these words of truth
and faith, everyone heard a door being opened, and heard the Holy
Spirit speak. 7 The king gathered every prophet and every person
present, and they came. Micaiah, aged Ananias, Joel, and Josab took
seats at his right and at his left. 8 When all of them heard the Holy
Spirit's voice, they knelt and bowed down, and gave glory to the true
God, the Most High, who dwells in the upper world and sits on high,
the Holy One who rests among his holy ones. 9 They gave glory to him
because he had opened a door in a foreign world, and had opened it
to a man. 10 As Isaiah was speaking by the Holy Spirit for everyone to
hear, he suddenly went quiet. His mind was lifted out of him, and he
no longer saw the men who stood before him, 11 though his eyes were
open. His lips were still, and the mind within his body had been taken
out of him. 12 Yet he was still breathing, because he was watching a
vision. 13 The angel who had been sent to show it to him was not
from this firmament, and he was not one of the glorious angels of
this world, but had come from the seventh heaven. 14 The bystanders
did not think so, but the company of the prophets believed the holy
Isaiah had been carried up. 15 The vision the holy Isaiah beheld did
not belong to this world; it came from the world kept hidden from
flesh. 16 When Isaiah had seen the vision, he described it to Hezekiah,
to his son Josab, and to the other prophets who had gathered. 17 But
the leaders, the eunuchs, and the people heard nothing. Only Samnas

the scribe, Joachim,[b] and Asaph the recorder heard, for they too did what is right, and the sweet fragrance of the Spirit rested on them. The people heard nothing, since Micaiah and his son Josab had sent them outside once the wisdom of this world was taken from Isaiah and he lay like a dead man.

Notes

- a (6:1) Greek *Galgala*, Hebrew *Gilgal*, “circle” or “rolling.”
- b (6:17) Ethiopic *Ijôaqêm*, Hebrew *Yehoyaqim*, “Yahweh raises up.”

Chapter 7

1 Isaiah described the vision he had seen to Hezekiah, his son Josab, Micaiah, and the other prophets. He said: 2 “A moment ago, while I was prophesying about the things you heard, I saw a glorious angel unlike the angels of glory that I used to see all the time. He had such glory and rank that I cannot describe his glory. 3 He took me by the hand and lifted me up, and I said to him, ‘Who are you? What is your name? And where are you taking me up to?’ I was given strength to speak with him. 4 He said to me, ‘When I have lifted you up through the different levels and shown you the vision I was sent to show, then you will understand who I am. But you do not know my name. 5 You will return to this body of yours, but you will see where I am lifting you up to, for I was sent for this purpose.’ 6 I was glad that he spoke so kindly to me. 7 He said to me, ‘Are you glad because I have spoken kindly to you?’ And he said, ‘You will see how one greater than I am will speak with you kindly and peacefully. 8 You will also see his Father, who is greater, for I was sent from the seventh heaven to explain all these things to you.’ 9 The two of us ascended to the firmament, and there I saw Sammael with his hosts. A great struggle was going on there, and Satan’s angels envied each other. 10 As it is above, so it is on the earth too, for what is on the earth is a likeness of what is in the firmament. 11 I asked the angel beside me, ‘What is the meaning of this war, and of this envy?’ 12 He answered, ‘It has been this way ever since the world was created, and this war will last until the one you will see arrives and destroys him.’ 13 Then he took me up above the firmament, to the first heaven. 14 There I saw a throne in the

center, and angels stood to the right of it and to the left. [15] The angels on the left were unlike those standing at the right. The ones on the right had greater glory, and they praised together in a single voice. A throne stood between them, and those on the left praised after them, but their voice was different from the right-hand angels' voice, and their praise was different too. [16] I asked the angel who was leading me, 'Who is this praise sent to?' [17] He said, 'It is offered to the One who sits in the seventh heaven, who rests in the holy world, together with his Beloved, who sent me to you. That is where it goes.' [18] Then he carried me up to the second heaven. That heaven is as high above the first as the heaven is above the earth and the firmament. [19] As in the first heaven, I saw angels on the right and the left, a throne in the center, and angels praising in the second heaven. The one seated on the throne in the second heaven shone more brightly than all the others. [20] The glory in the second heaven was immense, and its praise was not like the praise of the first heaven. [21] I fell on my face to bow before him, but the angel who guided me would not allow it. He said, 'Do not worship any throne or angel of the six heavens—that is why I was sent to guide you—until I say so in the seventh heaven. [22] Your throne has been placed above every heaven and their angels, and so have your garments and your crown, which you will see.' [23] Great joy filled me, because the lovers of the Most High and of his Beloved will one day rise to that place under the guidance of the angel of the Holy Spirit. [24] Next he took me up to the third heaven, and again I saw the angels at the right and the left, with a throne in the center. But there the memory of this world is never heard. [25] I spoke to the angel with me (my appearance was shining ever more brightly as I rose from heaven to heaven): 'Not even a trace of the emptiness of that world is spoken of here.' [26] He replied, 'Nothing is spoken of, because of its weakness; yet nothing that is done there stays hidden.' [27] I wanted to learn how it all becomes known, and he replied, 'When I have brought you to the seventh heaven, the one above these, from which I was sent, then you will know that nothing is concealed from the thrones, from the dwellers in the heavens, or from the angels.' The praise they offered and the glory of the one on the throne were great,

and the angels standing right and left had glory surpassing that of the heaven beneath. [28] Then he carried me up once more, to the fourth heaven; the distance from the third heaven to the fourth was larger than the distance from the earth to the firmament. [29] Once more I saw the angels at the right and the left, with the one seated on the throne between them, and they too were praising. [30] The right-hand angels' praise and glory were higher than those of the left-hand angels. [31] The glory of the one seated on the throne exceeded that of the right-hand angels, and their glory exceeded that of the ones below. [32] He lifted me to the fifth heaven. [33] Once more I saw the right and left, and the one on the throne, whose glory was higher than that of the fourth heaven's occupants. [34] The glory of the right-hand angels was higher than that of the left-hand ones, [35] and the one on the throne had more glory than the angels at his right. [36] Their praise was more splendid than the fourth heaven's. [37] I praised the one who has no name, the Only-begotten, who lives in the heavens and whose name no flesh knows, who has given each heaven its glory, who makes the glory of the angels great and increases still more the glory of the one who sits on the throne.

Chapter 8

[1] "Then he lifted me once more, into the sixth heaven's atmosphere, and I beheld a splendor unlike any I had seen in the five lower heavens. [2] I saw angels with great glory. [3] The praise there was holy and marvelous. [4] I asked the angel who guided me, 'What am I looking at, my lord?' [5] He said, 'I am not your lord, but your fellow servant.' [6] I asked him again, 'Why are there no angels on the left, as there are fellow servants of ours elsewhere?' [7] He replied, 'From the sixth heaven upward there are no more angels at the left, and no throne set in the center. They are ruled by the might of the seventh heaven, where the One without a name dwells, and the Chosen One, whose name has not been revealed, and no heaven can find out his name. [8] For he alone is the one whom all the heavens and thrones obey when he speaks. That is why I was given power and sent to bring you here, so that you could see this glory [9] and see the Lord of all those

heavens, along with these thrones, [10] as he alters his shape, stage by stage, until he looks like you in form and likeness. [11] I tell you, Isaiah: no one who is about to return into a body in that world has gone up or seen what you see, or understood what you have understood and what you will see. [12] You have been granted, by the Lord's allotment, to come here, and from here flows the power of the sixth heaven and the air.' [13] I praised my Lord, because through his allotment I was to come here. [14] He said, 'Hear this too, then, from your fellow servant: when, by God's will, you have left the body behind and gone up, you will be given the garment you see, and you will see other garments too, counted and kept there, [15] and then you will be the equal of the angels in the seventh heaven.' [16] He took me up to the sixth heaven, where there were no angels at the left and no throne in the center, but all looked alike, and their praise was the same. [17] Power was given to me too, and I praised with them, and that angel too, and our praise was like theirs. [18] There they all spoke the name of the first Father and of his Beloved, the Christ,[a] and of the Holy Spirit, all in one voice. [19] Their voice was unlike that of the angels in the five lower heavens, [20] or like their speech, but the voice there was different, and there was much light. [21] Once I was in the sixth heaven, I took the light I had seen in the lower five to be just darkness. [22] I was glad, and I praised him who has given such lights to those who wait for his promise. [23] I begged the angel who was leading me not to send me back to the fleshly world. [24] I tell you, Hezekiah, my son Josab, and Micaiah, that the darkness here is deep. [25] The angel guiding me knew my thoughts and said, 'If this light makes you rejoice, how much more you will rejoice when you see the light in the seventh heaven, where the Lord and his Beloved are, who sent me, and who is to be named "Son" in this world. He has not yet been revealed—he who will live in the perishing world— [26] and the garments, thrones, and crowns kept for the righteous, for those who put their trust in that Lord who will come down in your form. The light there is vast and marvelous. [27] As for your not returning to the body, your days are not yet complete for coming here.' [28] On hearing this I was troubled, and he told me, 'Let it not trouble you.'

Notes

- a (8:18) Greek *Christos*, "anointed one," the Greek for the Hebrew *mashiach* (Messiah).

Chapter 9

1 "He brought me to the seventh heaven's air, and I heard a voice say, 'How high will a being of flesh climb?' I was terrified and shook. 2 While I was trembling, I heard another voice sent from there saying, 'The holy Isaiah is permitted to come up here, for his garment is here.' 3 I asked the angel beside me, 'Who was it that forbade me, and who was it that permitted me to come up?' 4 He said to me, 'The one who forbade you is the one in charge of the praise of the sixth heaven. 5 The one who permitted it is your Lord God, the Lord Christ, who will go by the name Jesus[a] in the world. But his name you cannot hear until you have left your body behind.' 6 He raised me to the seventh heaven, and there I saw a marvelous light and countless angels. 7 There I saw all the righteous ever since Adam.[b] 8 There I saw the holy Abel[c] and all the righteous. 9 There I saw Enoch[d] and everyone with him, stripped of the garments of flesh. They wore their garments of the upper world and stood like angels in great glory. 10 But they were not sitting on their thrones, and their crowns of glory were not on them. 11 I asked the angel who accompanied me, 'Why have they received the garments, but not the thrones and the crowns?' 12 He said, 'They are not given crowns and thrones of glory until the Beloved descends in the form you will see him take when he comes into the world at the end of days—the Lord who will be given the name Christ. 13 Even so, they see and know whose thrones and crowns these will be when he has come down and been made in your form. They will think he is only flesh and a man. 14 The god of that world will reach out a hand against the Son, and they will nail him to a tree and kill him without knowing who he is. 15 So his descent, as you will see it, will be concealed even from the heavens, so that nobody will know who he is. 16 After he has plundered the angel of death, he will rise on the third day and remain in that world five hundred forty-five days.[e] 17 Then many of the righteous will rise along with him; their spirits are not given their garments until the Lord Christ goes up and they go

up with him. [18] Then they will receive their garments, thrones, and crowns, when he has gone up into the seventh heaven.' [19] I put to him the question I had asked in the third heaven: [20] 'Show me how everything that is done in that world is made known here.' [21] While I was still speaking with him, one of the angels who stood near, more glorious than the angel who had brought me up from the world, [22] showed me a book. He opened it, and it contained writing, but not like any book of this world. He handed it to me, and I read it: it recorded the deeds of the people of Israel, and of others unknown to me, my son Josab. [23] I said, 'Truly nothing that is done in this world is hidden in the seventh heaven.' [24] There I saw many garments laid up, with many thrones and many crowns. [25] I said to the angel, 'Whose are these garments, thrones, and crowns?' [26] He answered, 'Many from that world will be given these garments because they believed in the words of the One who will be named, as I told you; they will keep his commands, trust them, and trust in his cross. These are kept for them.' [27] I saw One standing there whose glory surpassed all the others. His glory was vast and wonderful. [28] When I had seen him, all the righteous I had seen, and the angels as well, drew near to him. Adam, Abel, and Seth[f] and all the righteous came forward first and bowed to him, and all of them praised him in one voice. I praised along with them, and my praise matched theirs. [29] Then all the angels came near, worshiped, and praised. [30] I was changed again and became like an angel. [31] Then the angel who was leading me said to me, 'Worship this One,' and I worshiped and praised. [32] The angel said to me, 'This is the Lord of all the praises that you have seen.' [33] As he was still speaking, I saw a second glorious One, similar to the first, and the righteous drew near, bowed, and praised, and I praised with them. But my glory was not changed to resemble theirs. [34] Then the angels came near and worshiped him. [35] There I saw the Lord with the second angel, both standing. [36] The second stood at my Lord's left. I asked, 'Who is this?' and he told me, 'Worship him. This is the Holy Spirit's angel, the one who speaks in you and in the other righteous.' [37] I saw the great glory with the eyes of my spirit open, and then I could not see, nor could my guiding angel, nor any of the angels I had watched worship my

Lord. [38] But I saw the righteous looking with great power on the glory of that One. [39] My Lord approached me, together with the angel of the Spirit, and said, ‘See that it has been granted you to look on God, and that power has been given, for your sake, to the angel who is with you.’ [40] I saw my Lord and the Spirit’s angel bow down, and the two of them praised God together. [41] Then all the righteous came near and worshiped. [42] The angels came near and worshiped, and all the angels praised.

Notes

- a (9:5) Greek *Iesous*, from Hebrew *Yeshua* (Joshua), “Yahweh saves.”
- b (9:7) Hebrew *Adam*, “human being,” from *adamah*, “ground.”
- c (9:8) Hebrew *Hevel*, “breath” or “vapor.”
- d (9:9) Hebrew *Chanokh*, “dedicated.”
- e (9:16) The words about the third day are found in the Greek Legend and the Ethiopic, but are missing in the Latin and Slavonic. The number 545 is found only in the Ethiopic.
- f (9:28) Hebrew *Shet*, “appointed” (Genesis 4:25).

Chapter 10

[1] “Then I heard the voices and the praise that I had heard in each of the lower six heavens, rising up and sounding there. [2] All of it was being sent up to that Glorious One, on whose glory I could not gaze. [3] I myself was hearing and seeing the praise given to him. [4] The Lord and the Spirit’s angel watched all this and listened to it all. [5] All the praises sent up from the six heavens can be seen as well as heard. [6] I heard my guiding angel say, ‘This is the Most High among the high ones, who dwells in the holy world and rests among his holy ones, and whom the Holy Spirit, speaking through the lips of the righteous, will call “the Father of the Lord.”’ [7] I heard the Most High, my Lord’s Father, speak to my Lord Christ, who will take the name Jesus: [8] ‘Go out and descend through all the heavens. You will descend to the firmament and to that world, to the angel in Sheol, but you will not go as far as Haguel.[a] [9] You will take on the likeness of everyone in the five heavens. [10] You will take care to look like the angels of the firmament, and like those in Sheol. [11] None of the angels of that world will know that you are Lord with me over the seven heavens and their

angels. [12] They will not know you are with me until I call out to the heavens, their angels, and their lights, as low as the sixth heaven, in a loud voice, so that you may judge and destroy the rulers, angels, and gods who belong to that world, and the realm under their rule. [13] For they have denied me, saying, "We alone exist, and no one is beside us." [14] After that you will rise from the angels of death to your own place, and you will not be changed in each heaven, but ascend in glory and sit at my right side. [15] Then the rulers and powers of that world will bow down to you.' [16] I heard the Great Glory giving these commands to my Lord. [17] I watched my Lord leave the seventh heaven for the sixth. [18] The angel guiding me told me, 'Pay attention, Isaiah, and watch how the Lord's transformation and descent will appear.' [19] I looked, and when the angels in the sixth heaven saw him, they praised and honored him, for he had not been changed into the shape of the angels there. They praised him, and I praised with them. [20] I saw him descend to the fifth heaven, and there he took the shape of that heaven's angels. They neither praised nor worshiped him, because he looked just as they did. [21] Then he descended to the fourth heaven and took the shape of its angels. [22] When they saw him, they gave him no praise or honor, since he looked like them. [23] Again I saw him descend, to the third heaven, where he took the form of the angels there. [24] The keepers of the third heaven's gate asked for the password, and the Lord gave it so that he would not be recognized. When they saw him, they offered no praise or honor, since his appearance matched theirs. [25] Again I saw him descend to the second heaven, and there too he gave the password. The gatekeepers kept demanding it, and the Lord kept giving it. [26] I saw him make himself like the second heaven's angels, and they looked at him and did not praise him, because he looked like them. [27] Again I saw him descend to the first heaven, and there too he gave the password to the gatekeepers and made himself like the angels who stood at the left of that throne. They neither praised nor honored him, since he looked like them. [28] But no one questioned me, because of the angel who was leading me. [29] Next he descended into the firmament, where this world's ruler lives, and told the password to those at the left. He looked like them, and they did

not praise him there. Instead they envied one another and fought, for evil has power there, and they quarrel over trifles. 30 I saw him descend and make himself resemble the angels of the air, so that he looked like one of them. 31 He gave no password, for there one was plundering and mistreating another.

Notes

- a (10:8) Ethiopic *Haguêl*, probably for Abaddon (Hebrew *Avaddon*, "destruction"), the final place of the lost; it is named only here.

Chapter 11

1 "After this the angel who spoke with me and led me said, 'Understand, Isaiah son of Amoz, for I was sent from God for this purpose.' 2 I saw a woman from the family of the prophet David, named Mary,[a] a virgin, engaged to a man called Joseph,[b] a carpenter, who also belonged to the line and household of the righteous David of Bethlehem in Judah. 3 He came into his allotment. When she was engaged, she was found to be with child, and Joseph the carpenter wanted to send her away. 4 But the Spirit's angel appeared in this world, and afterward Joseph did not divorce her; he kept Mary and told no one. 5 Joseph never went near Mary; he kept her a holy virgin even though she was pregnant. 6 For two months he did not live with her. 7 After two months, while Joseph was in his house with his wife Mary, the two of them alone, 8 it happened that when they were alone, Mary at once looked up and saw a small baby, and she was amazed. 9 After she was amazed, her womb was found as it had been before she conceived. 10 When her husband Joseph asked her, 'What has astonished you?' his eyes were opened; he saw the baby and praised God, for God had come into his portion. 11 A voice reached them: 'Do not tell anyone about this vision.' 12 The news about the baby spread in Bethlehem. 13 Some said, 'The virgin Mary has had a baby before she had been married two months.' 14 Many said, 'She has not had a baby, and no midwife went up to her, and we have not heard the cries of labor.' They were all blind about him, and they all knew about him, though they did not know where he was from. 15 They took him and went to Nazareth[c] in Galilee.[d] 16 Hezekiah and my son Josab, I saw

this, and I tell it to the other prophets standing here: it escaped all the heavens, all the rulers, and all the gods of this world. 17 I saw that in Nazareth he nursed at the breast as a baby, as is usual, so that he would not be recognized. 18 When he was grown he performed great signs and wonders in Israel's land and in Jerusalem. 19 After this the adversary grew jealous of him and roused the people of Israel against him, unaware of who he was; they delivered him to the king, crucified him, and he went down to the angel of Sheol. 20 I saw him in Jerusalem, crucified on a tree, 21 and likewise, after the third day, rising again and staying for days. 22 The angel who was leading me said, 'Understand, Isaiah.' And I saw him send out the twelve apostles and go up. 23 I saw him in the firmament, but he had not taken on their form; all the angels in the firmament, with the Satans, saw him and worshiped. 24 There was great grief there as they said, 'How did our Lord descend among us without our seeing the glory upon him—the glory we see has been on him since the sixth heaven?' 25 He went up to the second heaven without changing himself, and all the angels at the right and the left, and the throne in the center, 26 worshiped him and praised him, saying, 'How did our Lord pass us by on his way down, and we never noticed?' 27 In the same way he ascended to the third heaven, and they praised him and spoke as the others had. 28 In the fourth heaven and the fifth they spoke in just the same way. 29 But there was one glory, and he did not change himself from it. 30 I saw him ascend to the sixth heaven, and they bowed to him and glorified him. 31 But in every heaven the praise swelled louder. 32 I saw him go up to the seventh heaven, and every righteous person and every angel praised him. Then I saw him take his seat at the right of the Great Glory, on whose glory, as I told you, I could not look. 33 I also saw the angel of the Holy Spirit sitting at the left hand. 34 This angel said to me, 'Isaiah son of Amoz, that is enough for you, for these are great matters, since you have seen what no child of flesh has ever seen. 35 You will return into your garment of flesh until your days are completed. Then you will come here.'" 36 Isaiah saw these things and told them to everyone who stood before him, and they praised. He said to King Hezekiah, "I have spoken these things." 37 Both the end of this world, 38 and all this vision

will be completed in the last generations. [39] Isaiah made Hezekiah vow that he would not tell the people of Israel, nor give anyone these words to copy. [40] . . . You will read such things. Stay awake in the Holy Spirit so that you may receive your garments, thrones, and crowns of glory that are stored up in the seventh heaven. [41] Because of these visions and prophecies, Sammael Satan cut Isaiah son of Amoz, the prophet, in two with a saw, by Manasseh's hand. [42] Hezekiah handed all this over to Manasseh in the twenty-sixth year. [43] But Manasseh did not remember them or take them to heart; he became the servant of Satan and was destroyed. Here ends the vision of the prophet Isaiah, with his ascension.

Notes

- a (11:2) Greek *Maria*, from Hebrew *Miryam*; the meaning is uncertain.
- b (11:2) Hebrew *Yosef*, "may he add" (see the note at 4:22).
- c (11:15) Greek *Nazaret*, perhaps from Hebrew *netser*, "branch," or *notsrah*, "watcher"; the meaning is uncertain.
- d (11:15) Hebrew *Galil*, "circle" or "district."

Letter of Aristeas

Pseudepigrapha

Chapter 1

1 Philocrates,[a] the account of our meeting with Eleazar,[b] the high priest of the Jews, is worth telling. You have set great store by hearing it, by my going over each point and explaining why we were sent and for what purpose, and so I have tried to set it out plainly for you, knowing how much you love learning, 2 which is the highest good a person can have: to keep learning, and to keep taking in something further, whether through histories or through living the events oneself. For in this way a pure disposition is formed in the soul. It takes up what is finest, and, turning to piety, the most commanding thing of all, it governs itself by a rule that never misleads. 3 We were set on examining divine matters with care, and so we offered ourselves for an embassy to the man I mentioned. He is held in the highest honor for his nobility and good name by his citizens and by others, and he has won very great benefits for those with him and for his fellow citizens elsewhere. Our purpose was the translation of the divine law, since it is written among them on skins in Hebrew letters. 4 We carried this out eagerly, once we had found an opening with the king about the people who had been moved to Egypt from Judea[c] by the king's father, who had been the first to take possession of the city[d] and to take over Egypt.[e] It is worth telling you this as well. 5 I am convinced that you lean strongly toward reverence and toward the character of people who live by the holy law, and so you will gladly hear what we intend to tell. You have only lately come to us from the island,[f] and you wish to hear whatever helps to renew the soul. 6 I also sent you an account earlier of matters I thought worth remembering, which we received from the high priests of Egypt, that most learned land, about the people of the Jews. 7 You love learning, and so it is right to share with you whatever can benefit the mind. It is right to share it with all

who are like you, and much more with you, who hold such an honest conviction. You are not only my brother by kinship in character; you are also the same as I am in your eagerness for what is good. [8] For the charm of gold, or any other costly possession prized by the vain, does not bring the same benefit as the discipline of education and the care taken over it. But so that we do not become tiresome by dragging out the preliminaries, I will go back to the continuous course of the account. [9] Demetrius of Phalerum,[g] who had been put in charge of the king's library, was given large and varied sums in order to gather together, if he could, all the books in the inhabited world. By purchases and by copying, he carried the king's purpose as far toward its end as was in his power. [10] We were present when he was asked, "About how many tens of thousands of books are there?" He said, "More than two hundred thousand,[h] O king. I will take pains, within a short time, to bring the rest up to five hundred thousand.[i] I have been told that the laws of the Jews are also worth copying and worth a place in your library." [11] "What is stopping you from doing this?" the king asked. "Everything you need has been put at your disposal." Demetrius said, "They need translation. They use letters of their own, as the Egyptians have their own arrangement of letters, and they have a language of their own as well. They are assumed to use Syriac,[j] but that is not so; theirs is a different kind." The king took in each point and gave orders that a letter should go to the Jews' high priest, so that what had been said might be carried out.

Notes

- a (1:1) Greek *Philokrates*, "lover of power" or "lover of rule." He is the narrator's brother (verse 7).
- b (1:1) Hebrew *Elazar*, "God has helped."
- c (1:4) Greek *Ioudaia*, from Hebrew *Yehudah*, "praised."
- d (1:4) The city is Alexandria, named for Alexander the Great (Greek *Alexandros*, "defender of men").
- e (1:4) Greek *Aigyptos*; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- f (1:5) The text does not say which island is meant.
- g (1:9) Greek *Demetrios*, "devoted to Demeter," the goddess of grain; *Phaleron* was a harbor of Athens, and the meaning of its name is uncertain.
- h (1:10) Greek: "twenty myriads"; a myriad is ten thousand.
- i (1:10) Greek: "fifty myriads."

- j (1:11) Greek *Syriake*; here it probably means Aramaic, the language of Syria, which Jews of that time also spoke.

Chapter 2

1 I thought the moment had come to press what I had often asked of Sosibius[a] of Tarentum[b] and Andreas,[c] the chiefs of the bodyguard: the release of those who had been moved out of Judea by the king's father. For that king had gone through all of Coele-Syria[d] and Phoenicia,[e] using his success together with courage. Some people he deported, and others he took captive, bringing everything under his hand by fear. In the course of this he carried off to Egypt about a hundred thousand people[f] from the land of the Jews. 2 Of these he armed about thirty thousand[g] picked men and settled them in the country in the garrisons. (Many had already come in earlier, with the Persian[h], and others before them had been sent as allies to fight the king of the Ethiopians[i] with Psammetichus.[j] But those were not as many as the ones Ptolemy[k] son of Lagus[l] brought over.) 3 As I said, he chose those who were best in age and outstanding in strength and armed them. The rest of the crowd, older and younger and women as well, he left in servitude. This was not what he really wanted in his heart; he was overruled by his soldiers because of the services they had rendered in the struggles of war. When we found a pretext for their release, as I have already explained, we spoke to the king in these words. 4 "It would be absurd, O king, to be proved wrong by the facts themselves. A body of law lies before all the Jews, and we intend not only to copy it but to translate it. What reason could we give for sending it, while great numbers of the same people are in servitude in your kingdom? No, with a perfect and generous spirit, release those who are held in misery. For the God who gave them their law is guiding your kingdom, as I have found by inquiry.[m] 5 They worship the God who oversees all things and created them, whom all people worship, and we as well, O king, though under other names, Zeus and Dios.[n] The first people to name him this way did so fittingly: that by which everything receives life and comes into being is the guide and lord of all. You surpass all people in the brightness of your mind, so release

those who are held in servitude." [6] After a short time, as we prayed in our hearts to God that he would shape the king's mind toward the release of them all (for the human race is God's creation, and God changes and turns it as he wishes; so in many and various ways I called on the one who rules the heart, that he might be compelled, as I asked, to do it), [7] for I had great hope, as I made my plea for the rescue of human beings, that God would bring about what was asked. What people believe they are doing in holiness, for justice and the care of good works, is directed in its deeds and plans by God, who rules over all. [8] The king looked up, glanced at me with a cheerful face, and said, "About how many tens of thousands do you think they will number?" Andreas, who was standing by, answered, "A little over a hundred thousand." "A small thing indeed," the king said, "that Aristeas[o] asks of us." Sosibius and some of those present said, "It is also worthy of your generosity to present their release to the most high God as an offering of thanks. You have been honored supremely by the one who rules all things, and made more glorious than your ancestors. So if you make very great thank offerings, it is fitting for you." [9] The king was greatly delighted. He ordered that the soldiers' pay be increased, that twenty drachmas[p] be paid for each person, and that an order be issued about this, with the registrations made at once. He acted with generous eagerness, since God was bringing to completion our whole purpose and forcing the king to ransom not only the men who had arrived along with his father's army but also anyone who had been there before or was brought into the kingdom afterward. They reckoned the payment at more than four hundred talents (about 30,000 pounds of silver).[q] [10] I think it is useful to include a copy of the order as well. The king's generosity will be far clearer and more obvious, since God was strengthening him to bring rescue to so many multitudes. [11] It read as follows. "By order of the king: All those who served in the army with our father in the regions of Syria[r] and Phoenicia, and who entered the land of the Jews and gained possession of Jewish persons and brought them to the city and the country, or sold them to others, and likewise anyone who had them earlier or has had them brought in since, are to release them at once, for money. Each owner is to receive

twenty drachmas for each person: soldiers as an addition to their pay, and the others from the royal bank. 12 We consider that these people were taken captive against our father's wish and contrary to what is right, and that, because of the recklessness of soldiers, their land was laid waste and the removal of the Jews to Egypt took place. The gain the soldiers made in the field was enough. Therefore the oppression of human beings is altogether unreasonable. 13 We acknowledge that justice is owed to all people, and much more to those who are wrongly oppressed. We seek in every way what is right toward justice and toward piety for all. We therefore order that all Jewish persons who are in servitude anywhere in the kingdom, in whatever way, are to be released by those who hold them, on receipt of the stated sum, and that no one is to handle these matters with malicious delay. The registrations are to be made within three days from the day this order is posted, before those appointed for the purpose, and the persons are to be produced at once. 14 We judge that this will serve us and our affairs. Whoever wishes to report those who disobey may do so, on the understanding that he will gain control of the one found guilty. The property of such people will be taken into the royal treasury." 15 The order was brought in to be read to the king, and it contained all of this except the words "and anyone who had them earlier or has had them brought in since." The king added this himself, in his generosity and greatness of spirit. He also ordered that the whole sum of the payments be divided up among the officers' attendants in the divisions and the royal bankers. 16 So it was decided and confirmed within seven days. The payment came to more than six hundred sixty talents (about 49,500 pounds of silver).[s] Many nursing infants were set free with their mothers, too. When the king was asked whether the twenty drachmas would be paid for these as well, he ordered that this too be done, carrying out completely what he had decided.

Notes

- a (2:1) Greek *Sosibios*, "life-saving."
- b (2:1) Greek *Taras*, a Greek city of southern Italy; the meaning of the name is uncertain.
- c (2:1) Greek *Andreas*, "manly."

- d (2:1) Greek *Koile Syria*, “Hollow Syria,” the valley country between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon ranges, later used for all of southern Syria.
- e (2:1) Greek *Phoinike*, perhaps “land of purple.”
- f (2:1) Greek: “ten myriads.”
- g (2:2) Greek: “three myriads.”
- h (2:2) Greek *Persēs*; the Persian king Cambyses (reigned 530–522 BC) conquered Egypt. The name is Old Persian, perhaps from *Pārsa*, the land of Persia.
- i (2:2) Greek *Aithiopes*, “burnt-faced.”
- j (2:2) Greek *Psammitichos*, from the Egyptian royal name Psamtik; the meaning is uncertain.
- k (2:2) Greek *Ptolemaios*, “warlike.”
- l (2:2) Greek *Lagos*, “hare.”
- m (2:4) The Greek of the last clause is awkward, and the sentence may be damaged.
- n (2:5) Greek *Zeus* and *Dios* are the nominative and genitive forms of the same Greek name; the two forms were read as meaning “through whom” (*di’ hon*) life comes.
- o (2:8) Greek *Aristeas*, “best” or “excellent.”
- p (2:9) A drachma was a Greek silver coin; the amount is left unconverted because its buying power varied.
- q (2:9) Greek: “over four hundred talents.” A talent is taken here as about 75 pounds (34 kg); the weights used for talents varied. The text does not name the metal, and silver is assumed.
- r (2:11) Greek *Syria*, probably a shortened form of *Assyria*.
- s (2:16) Greek: “more than six hundred sixty talents.” A talent is taken here as about 75 pounds (34 kg).

Chapter 3

1 When this had been accomplished, the king ordered Demetrius to submit a proposal about the copying of the Jewish books. Everything under these kings was handled by written orders and with great care, and nothing was done carelessly or at random. For this reason I have included the text of the proposal and copies of the letters, the number of the gifts sent, and the workmanship of each, since every one of them stood out for its lavishness and skill. This is a copy of the proposal. 2 “To the great king, from Demetrius. You gave orders, O king, that the books still missing to complete the library be gathered in, and that those that have fallen into disrepair receive proper restoration. I have given careful attention to these matters, and I now report the following to you. 3 The books of the law of the

Jews are missing, along with a few others. They happen to be written in Hebrew letters and language, but they have been set down rather carelessly and not as they really stand, as those who know them report; for they have never had the king's care. 4 It is necessary that these too be in your possession in an exact form, since this legislation is wiser and unspoiled, as one would expect of a divine law. For that reason, writers, poets, and the whole crowd of historians have kept their distance from mentioning these books and the men who have lived and still live by them, because the thinking in them is pure and solemn, as Hecataeus of Abdera[a] says. 5 If it seems good to you, O king, a letter will be written to the high priest in Jerusalem[b] to send elderly men whose lives have been the best, experienced in their own law, six from each tribe. We will then examine what the majority agree on, obtain an accurate translation, and set it down clearly, in a way worthy of the matter and of your purpose. May you prosper always." 6 When this proposal had been presented, the king ordered a letter to be written to Eleazar about these matters, reporting also the release of the captives that had taken place. He gave, too, for the making of mixing bowls, cups, a table, and bowls for pouring offerings, fifty talents' weight of gold (about 3,750 pounds)[c] and seventy talents of silver (about 5,250 pounds), along with a great quantity of precious stones. He ordered the keepers of the treasure chests to let the craftsmen choose whichever stones they preferred. He also gave coined money for sacrifices and other needs, nearly a hundred talents (about 7,500 pounds of silver). 7 I will tell you about the workmanship once I have gone through the copies of the letters. The king's letter was in this form. 8 "King Ptolemy sends Eleazar the high priest greetings, and wishes him health. It has happened that many Jews have been settled in our country, having been carried off from Jerusalem by the Persians during the time they ruled, and that others came to Egypt with our father as captives. 9 Of these our father enrolled many in the army on higher pay. He also judged those who were there earlier to be trustworthy, built forts, and handed these over to them, so that the nation of the Egyptians would be afraid because of them. Now that we have taken over the kingdom, we deal with everyone more kindly,

and much more so with your fellow citizens. [10] We have set free more
than a hundred thousand captives, giving their owners the silver they
were owed, and putting right whatever was done wrongly through
the rush of the crowds. We have judged that this was a pious thing
to do, and we offer it in thanks to the greatest God, who has held
our realm in peace and raised it to the height of glory throughout
the whole inhabited world. We have placed those in the prime of life
in the army, and those who are able to be near us and are worthy
of trust at court we have set over our affairs. [11] We wish to show
favor both to these people and to all the Jews in the world, and to
those who come after them. We have therefore decided that your law
be translated into Greek letters from the Hebrew letters, as they are
called among you, so that these books too may be in our library with
the other royal books. [12] You will do well, and in a manner worthy of
our eagerness, to choose elderly men who have lived good lives, who
are experienced in the law and able to translate it, six from each tribe,
so that agreement may be found among the larger number, since the
inquiry concerns weighty matters. For we believe that when this is
finished we will win great fame. [13] We have sent Andreas, of the chiefs
of the bodyguard, and Aristeas, who are held in honor among us,
to talk with you. They are bringing first offerings of dedicated gifts
for the temple, and a hundred talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds)
for sacrifices and other needs. If you write to us about whatever you
wish, you will please us and do something worthy of friendship, and
what you choose will be carried out as quickly as possible. Farewell."
[14] Eleazar answered this letter, in suitable terms. It went like this:
"Eleazar, high priest, to King Ptolemy, his true friend: greetings. May
you be well, and the queen Arsinoe,[d] your sister, and your children;
it would be as we wish. We are well also. [15] When we received your
letter, we rejoiced greatly over your purpose and your good plan. We
gathered the whole community and read it aloud to them, so that they
would learn how devout you are toward our God. We also showed
them the gifts you sent: bowls, twenty of gold and thirty of silver,
with five mixing bowls, and a table for dedication, and a hundred

talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds) for bringing sacrifices and for repairs of whatever the temple needs,

Notes

- a (3:4) Greek *Hekataios*, perhaps "far-shooter," a title of the god Apollo; *Abdera* was a Greek city on the coast of Thrace, and the meaning of its name is uncertain.
- b (3:5) Greek *Hierosolyma*, from Hebrew *Yerushalayim*, perhaps "foundation of peace."
- c (3:6) Greek: "fifty talents." A talent is taken here as about 75 pounds (34 kg); the weights used for talents varied.
- d (3:14) Greek *Arsinoe*, perhaps "man-minded." She was the king's sister and wife.

Chapter 4

1 for we will obey in everything that is to your advantage, even if it goes against our nature, since this is a sign of friendship and affection. You, too, have done great and unforgettable good to our citizens in many ways. 2 Immediately, then, we offered sacrifices for you, for your sister, your children, and your friends. The whole community prayed that all you intend may always come to you, that God, who rules over all, may keep your kingdom safe in peace and glory, and that the copying of the holy law may be carried out to your benefit and in safety. 3 In the presence of everyone we chose good and fine elderly men, six from each tribe, and we have sent them with the law. You will do well, righteous king, to give orders that when the copying of the books is finished, the men are brought back to us again in safety. Farewell." 4 These are the men. From the first tribe: Joseph, Hezekiah, Zechariah, John, Hezekiah, Elisha.[a] From the second: Judah, Simon, Samuel, Adaeus, Mattathias, Eschlemias.[b] From the third: Nehemiah, Joseph, Theodosius, Baseas, Ornias, Dakis.[c] 5 From the fourth: Jonathan, Abaeus, Elisha, Hananiah, Chabrias, Chelkias (this last name is doubtful in the Greek).[d] From the fifth: Isaac, Jacob, Jesus, Sabbataeus, Simon, Levi.[e] From the sixth: Judah, Joseph, Simon, Zechariah, Samuel, Selemias.[f] 6 From the seventh: Sabbataeus, Zedekiah, Jacob, Isaac, Jesias, Natthaeus.[g] From the eighth: Theodosius, Jason, Jesus, Theodotus, John, Jonathan.[h] From the ninth: Theophilus, Abram, Arsamus, Jason, Endemias, Daniel.[i] 7 From the tenth: Jeremiah, Eleazar, Zechariah, Baneas, Elisha, Dathaeus.[j] From

the eleventh: Samuel, Joseph, Judah, Jonathan, Chabeu, Dositheus.[k] From the twelfth: Isael, John, Theodosius, Arsamus, Abietes, Ezekiel.[l] In all they were seventy-two. 8 Such was the reply that Eleazar and those with him made to the king's letter. I will now do as I promised and describe the works of craftsmanship. They were completed with outstanding skill, since the king contributed lavishly and looked in on the craftsmen at every stage. So they could not overlook anything or finish anything carelessly. First I will explain to you what concerns the table. 9 The king was eager to make the piece enormous in its measurements. He ordered inquiry to be made of people in that region about how large the table already standing in the temple in Jerusalem was. 10 When they told him the measurements, he asked whether he should also make a larger one. Some of the priests, and others, said that nothing prevented it. He said he wished to make it five times the size, but he was afraid it might become useless for the services. 11 For he did not want what came from him merely to sit in that place. He would be far more pleased if the proper services were carried out correctly on the pieces he had made, by those to whom that duty fell. 12 "The earlier pieces are small," he said, "not for lack of gold; it appears that they were made to these measures for some reason. If there had been an instruction to make them larger, nothing would have been withheld. So what has been rightly done must not be overstepped or set aside." 13 He ordered them to use as much variety of craftsmanship as possible, planning everything with dignity and having a fine natural sense for the expressiveness of things. Where nothing was prescribed in writing, he ordered them to make it beautiful; where it was prescribed in writing, the measures were to follow it. 14 They made it two cubits (3 feet) long and a cubit and a half (27 inches) high,[m] working it in tested gold, solid all the way through. I mean that the gold was not wrapped around some other material; the hammered plate itself was joined together. 15 They made a rim a palm (about 3 inches) wide[n] all around. The moldings were twisted, carved in relief with a pattern of cords, and wonderful in their run when seen from the three sides, for the piece was three-cornered. 16 On each side the design of the work had the same arrangement, so

that whichever side was turned, the appearance was the same. With the molding laid along the rim, the slope toward the table itself held the pattern of beauty, and the outward slope faced the view of the person approaching. [17] So the ridge between the two slopes came to a sharp edge, standing up, as we said, because it was built three-cornered whichever side was turned. Settings of costly stones lay in it between the cords, one beside another, with a weaving that no one could imitate. [18] All were held through drilled holes by gold pins for security. At the corners, clasps drew them tight to hold them together. [19] At the sides, around the rim, on the part facing upward, a pattern of eggs was made with stones set in it, with a design that drew the eye in continuous fluted reliefs, set close together all around the table. [20] Beneath the stone-set pattern of eggs the craftsmen made a wreath of every kind of fruit, standing out clearly in relief: bunches of grapes and heads of grain, with dates, apples, olives, pomegranates, and the like. They cut the stones to the shapes of these fruits, each kind in its own color, and bound them in the gold, all around the whole edge of the table. [21] After the arrangement of the wreath, the same pattern was made as for the eggs, and the rest of the fluting and carving was done in the same way. This was because the table was made usable on both sides, whichever side was lifted, so that the placing of the moldings and of the rim was also at the end where the legs were. [22] They made a solid plate four fingers (about 3 inches) thick[o] across the whole width of the table, so that the legs could be set into it, fastened with pins and clasps at the rim. That way, whichever side was lifted would be the one in use. This can be seen on the surface, since the piece was made to be used either way up. [23] On the table itself they made a meander in relief, with costly stones standing out in the middle of it, of various kinds: carbuncles and emeralds, onyx, and other kinds outstanding in beauty. [24] After the arrangement of the meander lay a latticework, wonderful to see, making a diamond pattern in the middle. On it a crystal stone and what is called electrum[p] were set in relief, making a sight that no one could imitate. [25] They made the legs with capitals shaped like lilies, with the lilies bending back beneath the table, and the face toward the inside had its petals standing straight. [26] The base

on which the leg rested on the floor was a palm (about 3 inches) high on every side and made of stone, set like a plinth in appearance, and eight fingers (about 6 inches) wide. On it rested the whole plate of the leg.[q] 27 They made ivy growing out of the stone, interwoven with acanthus, winding with a vine around the leg, with clusters of grapes, which were also worked in stone, up to the top. The same arrangement was used on all four legs. Everything was made so lifelike and fitted so well that the skill of the craftsmen matched the real thing exactly. Even when a breath of wind stirred the air, the leaves would move, since everything was modeled on the living thing. 28 They made the top of the table in three parts, like a three-leaved panel, fitted to one another with dovetail joints through the thickness of the piece, and they made the joining of the seams so that it could not be seen or found. The thickness of the whole table was not less than half a cubit (about 9 inches), so that the whole piece was worth many talents. 29 For the king had decided not to add anything to the size, and what would have had to be spent on making larger pieces he gave instead for these, in greater amount. According to his plan, everything was completed wonderfully and notably, inimitable in its craftsmanship and outstanding in beauty. 30 Of the mixing bowls, two were made of gold. They had a scale pattern that ran from the base to the middle, and between the scales stones were set with great skill. 31 Then came a meander a cubit (18 inches) high, with its relief in varied stonework, showing with beauty the painstaking labor of the craft. Above this was fluting, and above that an interweaving of diamond shapes with a net-like face, all the way up to the mouth. 32 In the middle were little shields of stones, one beside another, each of a different kind, not less than four fingers (about 3 inches) across, and they filled out the clear beauty of the piece. On the rim of the body a relief of lilies with honeysuckle ornaments, and twisting cords of grape clusters, were modeled all around. 33 The gold ones had this construction, and each held more than two measures (more than 20 gallons).[r] The silver ones had a smooth surface that served as a mirror, wonderful for this purpose, so that anything brought near was reflected more clearly than in ordinary mirrors. 34 It is not possible

to describe what was accomplished for the sake of lifelike effect. When the pieces were finished and set one beside another (I mean first a silver bowl, then a gold one, then silver and gold again), the effect on the eye was altogether indescribable, and those who came to look could not tear themselves away, because of the dazzling light and the pleasure of the sight. 35 The effect of the surface was varied. Those who looked at the gold work felt a spell of wonder, as the mind turned continually to each piece of craft. And when someone wished to look at the arrangement of the silver pieces, everything shone around from every side, wherever one stood, and increased the delight of those who watched. So the many arts used in them were beyond description. 36 The gold cups they engraved with wreaths of vine in the middle, and around the rims they wove a wreath in relief of ivy, myrtle, and olive, setting costly stones in them. The rest of the work they finished in different ways, all of them striving to add to the king's glory. 37 All in all, no work of such expense and craftsmanship existed in the royal treasuries or anywhere else. The king took no small care, since he loved glory in fine things. 38 He often put aside public business and sat attentively beside the craftsmen, so that they would finish the works in a way fitting to the place to which they were being sent. So everything was done with dignity, and worthy of the king who sent it and of the high priest who presided over the place. 39 The number of stones was lavish, and they were large, not fewer than five thousand, and all were of the highest craftsmanship, so that the gift of the stones and the work of the craftsmen were worth five times the gold.

Notes

- a (4:4) Greek forms of Hebrew names. In order: Joseph (*Yosef*), "may he add"; Hezekiah (*Chizqiyah*), "Yahweh strengthens"; Zechariah (*Zekharyah*), "Yahweh remembers"; John (*Yochanan*), "Yahweh is gracious"; Hezekiah again; Elisha (*Elisha*), "God saves." The Greek text gives the tribes by number, not by name.
- b (4:4) In order: Judah (*Yehudah*), "praised"; Simon (Greek form of *Shim'on*, Simeon), "he has heard"; Samuel (*Shemu'el*), "name of God" or "God has heard"; Adaeus, perhaps from *Adayah*, "Yahweh has adorned"; Mattathias (*Mattityah*),

"gift of Yahweh"; Eschlemias, perhaps from *Shelemyah*, "Yahweh repays," but the name is uncertain.

- c (4:4) In order: Nehemiah (*Nechemyah*), "Yahweh comforts"; Joseph; Theodosius, a Greek name meaning "gift of God"; Baseas, Ornias, and Dakis, whose meanings are uncertain.
- d (4:5) In order: Jonathan (*Yehonatan*), "Yahweh has given"; Abaeus, meaning uncertain; Elisha; Hananiah (*Chananyah*), "Yahweh has been gracious"; Chabrias, a Greek name, perhaps "graceful"; Chelkias, perhaps for Hilkiah (*Chilqiyah*), "Yahweh is my portion."
- e (4:5) In order: Isaac (*Yitschaq*), "he laughs"; Jacob (*Ya'aqov*), "he grasps the heel" or "may God protect"; Jesus, the Greek form of *Yeshua*, Joshua, "Yahweh saves"; Sabbataeus, "born on the Sabbath"; Simon; Levi (*Levi*), "joined."
- f (4:5) Selemias, perhaps for Shelemiah (*Shelemyah*), "Yahweh repays" or "Yahweh is peace." The other names are explained above.
- g (4:6) In order: Sabbataeus; Zedekiah (*Tsidqiyah*), "Yahweh is my righteousness"; Jacob; Isaac; Jesias, perhaps for Isaiah or Joshua; Natthaeus, meaning uncertain.
- h (4:6) Jason, a Greek name meaning "healer," often used by Jews in place of Joshua; Theodotus, a Greek name meaning "given by God."
- i (4:6) In order: Theophilus, "friend of God"; Abram (*Avram*), "exalted father"; Arsamus, a name of Persian or Semitic origin, meaning uncertain; Jason; Endemias, meaning uncertain; Daniel (*Daniyel*), "God is my judge."
- j (4:7) Jeremiah (*Yirmeyahu*), "Yahweh lifts up" or "Yahweh loosens"; Baneas, perhaps for Benaiah (*Benayahu*), "Yahweh has built"; Dathaeus, meaning uncertain.
- k (4:7) Chabeu, meaning uncertain; Dositheus, a Greek name meaning "gift of God."
- l (4:7) Isael, perhaps for Israel (*Yisra'el*), "he struggles with God"; Abietes, perhaps for Abiah (*Aviyah*), "Yahweh is my father"; Ezekiel (*Yechezqel*), "God strengthens."
- m (4:14) Greek: "two cubits" and "a cubit and a half"; a cubit is taken as 18 inches (45 cm).
- n (4:15) Greek: a "palm," one-fourth of a cubit's measure of six palms, taken here as about 3 inches (7.5 cm).
- o (4:22) Greek: "four fingers"; a finger is taken as about three-quarters of an inch (1.9 cm).
- p (4:24) Greek *elektron*, which can mean either amber or an alloy of gold and silver.
- q (4:26) The Greek of this verse is damaged, and the sense is uncertain.
- r (4:33) Greek: "more than two *metretai*." A *metretes* is taken here as about 10 gallons (39 L); the size varied from place to place.

Chapter 5

1 I thought a record of these things was also necessary, and so I have made them plain to you. Next comes the account of our trip to Eleazar; before that, I will describe the lie of the whole country. When we reached those parts, we saw the city lying in the middle of all Judea, on a mountain rising to a great height. 2 On the summit the temple had been built, splendid to look at. It had three enclosing walls, each more than seventy cubits (about 105 feet) in size,[a] and the breadth and length matched the design of the house itself. Everything was built with a grandeur and lavishness that surpassed all else. 3 The doorway, the fastenings around it along the doorposts, and the strength of the lintels made it plain that money had been spent without stint. 4 The curtain was made very much like the doorway in every respect. Because the air moved beneath it, the woven fabric was kept in constant motion, as the billowing, which began at the floor, stretched all the way up to the top. The sight was pleasant and hard to turn away from. 5 The altar was built to suit the place, and the sacrifices that were burned up by fire were offered on it. The approach to the altar was laid out for good order, and the priests who served were covered down to the ankles in tunics of fine linen. 6 The house faces east, with its back to the west. The whole floor is paved with stone and slopes toward suitable places so that water can be carried off, which is needed to wash away the blood of the sacrifices; for tens of thousands of animals are brought in on feast days. 7 The supply of water never fails. A spring with abundant flow wells up naturally from within, and there are also wonderful and indescribable reservoirs underground, reaching, as they showed us, five stadia (about 3,000 feet) around the foundation of the temple.[b] From each of these run countless pipes, where the streams join together on every side. 8 All of these were lined with lead on the floor and the wall, and a great quantity of plaster had been poured over them, everything done with care. There were many openings at the base, invisible to everyone except those who perform the service, so that at a signal all the blood of the great mass of sacrifices that collects can be washed away. 9 I will describe the construction of the reservoirs as I myself became convinced of it.

They led me out of the city more than four stadia (about half a mile), and at one place they told me to bend down and listen to the noise of the waters meeting. In this way the size of the vessels became clear to me, as I have said. [10] The service of the priests is in every respect unsurpassed in strength and in orderly, silent arrangement. All work hard of their own accord, though it is very toilsome, and each one cares for what has been assigned to him. They serve without pause, some bringing wood, others oil, others fine flour, others spices, and others burning the flesh of the offerings, using exceptional strength. [11] They take hold of the calves' legs with both hands (each calf weighs about two talents or more, about 150 pounds)[c] and fling them up to a wonderful height, one with each hand, and never miss the placing. The sheep and goats, too, are remarkable for weight and fat. Those in charge always choose animals without blemish and outstanding in plumpness, and so what I have described is accomplished. [12] A place is set aside for their rest, where those who are taking a break sit. When that happens, those of the others who have stopped rise up eagerly, with no one giving orders for the service. [13] Complete silence prevails, so that one would suppose no human being was present in the place, though the ministers there number about seven hundred, besides a great crowd of those bringing offerings. Yet everything is carried out with reverence, in a way worthy of great divinity. [14] It caused us great astonishment when we saw Eleazar at his service, with the splendor of his dress and the glory that comes from the robe he wears and the stones about him. Golden bells hang around his ankle-length robe, giving out a distinctive sound of melody, and beside each of these are little pomegranates embroidered with flowers, wonderful in color. [15] He was girded with a splendid belt of unusual make, woven through with the loveliest colors. On his chest he wears what is called the breastpiece, in which twelve stones of different kinds are fastened, set in gold, with the names of the tribal leaders in the order established from the beginning. Each one flashes out the natural color proper to it, beyond description. [16] He wears on his head the so-called turban, and on that the inimitable headband, the consecrated royal emblem, with the name of God[d] stamped in

sacred letters on a gold plate in the middle of his brow. He is full of glory, since he was judged worthy of these things for the services. [17] The sight of all this brings fear and confusion, so that one thinks one has come into another world outside this one. I assure you that every person who comes near to see the things I have described will be filled with amazement and indescribable wonder, his mind changed by the holy arrangement of every part. [18] To get to know everything, we climbed to the citadel beside the city and looked around. It stands in a very high place, secured by many towers, which were built up to the top with long stones, as we learned, to guard the places around the temple, [19] so that if there should be an attack, an uprising, or an assault by enemies, no one could force a way into the enclosures around the house. Arrow-shooting engines stood on the towers of the citadel, and engines of various kinds, and the place lay above the enclosures I have described, [20] and the towers were guarded by the most trustworthy men, who had given great proofs of loyalty to their country. They had no authority to leave the citadel except on feast days, and then only some of them, and they allowed no one to come in. [21] They were very strict even when an order came through the one in command to admit certain people to see the place, as happened in our own case. They barely admitted the two of us, unarmed, to observe the sacrifices. [22] They said that this was also confirmed by oaths. All of them had sworn, under the compulsion of their religion, to keep the rule: since there were five hundred of them, no more than five persons could be let in together. For the whole guarding of the temple is the citadel, and whoever is in charge of it is made secure in this way against the dangers I have mentioned. [23] The extent of the city is proportionate, with a circuit of about forty stadia (about 4½ miles), as far as one can estimate. The towers are arranged like the rows of a theater, and passages can be seen, some lower down and some above, with ways through them. The ground slopes because the city is built on a mountain, and stairways lead up to the passages. [24] Some people take their road on the upper level and others beneath, and they keep well away from the road, because of those who are in states of purification, so that they touch nothing they should not.

25 It was not without reason that the first builders laid out the city
in fitting proportion; they planned it wisely. The country is large
and fine. Some of it is plain, the part around what is called Samaria[e]
and the parts adjoining the land of the Idumeans,[f] and some is
mountainous, the part adjoining the land of the Jews. These regions
need constant attention to farming and the care of the soil, so that the
people may have good harvests. This is what is done, and all of it is
farmed with great abundance in the whole country I have described. 26
As for the cities, those of great size and a matching prosperity tend to
be well populated while the countryside is neglected, since everyone
is inclined toward cheerfulness of spirit, and by their very make-up
all human beings are prone to pleasures. 27 That is what happened
around Alexandria, which surpasses all cities in size and prosperity.
People who came into it from the country as visitors stayed on for
a long time and caused farming to decline. 28 So, to keep them from
staying, the king ordered that no one remain as a visitor for more
than twenty days. He also gave written instructions to the officials,
that if it was necessary to summon anyone, they should decide the
matter within five days. 29 He gave great weight also to the revenue
officers and their assistants, and he appointed them by districts, so
that the farmers and the city's leading men, by making profit, would
not run down the storehouses, I mean the produce of farming. 30 We
have gone off on this subject because Eleazar showed us the things
above so well. The industry of those who farm is great. The country
is full of olive trees in large numbers, of grain crops and pulses, and
also of vines and abundant honey. Other tree fruits and dates are
not even counted among them. 31 There are many mixed herds, and
abundant pasture for them. For that reason they saw rightly that the
region needs a large population, and they laid out the city and the
villages accordingly. 32 A great quantity of spices, costly stones, and
gold is brought to the place through the Arabs.[g] The country is made
for working and trade, the city is rich in crafts, and nothing brought
by sea is lacking. 33 It has convenient harbors that supply it: the one
at Ascalon,[h] Joppa,[i] and Gaza,[j] and also Ptolemais,[k] which the king
founded. Jerusalem lies in the middle of these places and not far from

them. The country has everything in abundance, well watered on every side and very secure. 34 The river called the Jordan,[l] which never stops flowing, runs around it. In ancient times the land measured no less than sixty million arouras (about forty million acres),[m] though later the neighbors encroached on it, and six hundred thousand men were established as landholders, each with a hundred arouras (about seventy acres). The river fills, like the Nile,[n] in the days of the harvest, and it waters much of the land. 35 This river sends its stream into another river in the territory of Ptolemais, and that one goes out to the sea. Other streams called torrents run down, taking in the parts toward Gaza and the land of the Azotians.[o] 36 The country is enclosed by natural defenses. It is hard to invade and impassable for large forces, because the approaches are narrow, with cliffs alongside and deep ravines, and the whole mountain range surrounding the entire country is rugged. 37 It was also said that mines of copper and iron used to be worked in the neighboring mountains of Arabia. These were abandoned in the time when the Persians ruled, because those then in charge spread the charge that working them was useless and very expensive, 38 so that, because of the mining of those metals, the country would not be ruined and, in effect, taken over through their power, since they would have a pretext for entering the land. I have now given you a summary of what was needed on these matters, my brother Philocrates. What concerns the translation I will explain in what follows.

Notes

- a (5:2) Greek: “seventy cubits”; a cubit is taken as 18 inches (45 cm). The Greek says “in size,” and height is probably meant.
- b (5:7) Greek: “five stadia.” A stadion is taken as about 600 feet (185 m); five stadia is therefore just over half a mile.
- c (5:11) Greek: “more than two talents.” A talent is taken here as about 75 pounds (34 kg).
- d (5:16) The name Yahweh, in holy Hebrew letters, is meant.
- e (5:25) Greek *Samareitis*, from Hebrew *Shomron*, “watch hill.”
- f (5:25) Greek *Idoumaioi*, the people of Edom, whose name means “red.”
- g (5:32) Greek *Arabes*, from a Semitic word probably meaning “desert dwellers” or “nomads.”
- h (5:33) Greek *Askalon*, Hebrew *Ashqelon*; the meaning is uncertain.

- i (5:33) Hebrew *Yafo*, “beautiful.”
- j (5:33) Hebrew *Azzah*, “strong.”
- k (5:33) Greek *Ptolemais*, “city of Ptolemy”; this was the old Phoenician port of Acco, renamed for a Ptolemy.
- l (5:34) Hebrew *Yarden*, “descender.”
- m (5:34) Greek: “six thousand myriads of *aroura*.” An *aroura* is taken as about two-thirds of an acre (0.28 hectare).
- n (5:34) Greek *Neilos*; the origin of the name is uncertain.
- o (5:35) Greek *Azotioi*, the people of Azotus, Hebrew *Ashdod*, “fortress.”

Chapter 6

1 For Eleazar had picked the best men, outstanding in education, since they came from distinguished parents. They had not only gained a command of the Jewish writings but had also paid serious attention to Greek learning. 2 For this reason they were well suited for embassies and carried them out whenever it was needed. They also had great natural ability in conversation and in discussions about the law. They pursued the middle course, which is the finest, laying aside what is rough and uncultured in the mind. Likewise they had risen above conceit and the belief that they were superior to others. They had taken up courtesy, listening, and giving each person a fitting answer. All of them kept these habits, and each wanted to outdo the others in them, and all were worthy of their leader and of his excellence. 3 It was easy to see how they loved Eleazar and could hardly be parted from him, and he loved them. Besides writing to the king about their return, he urged Andreas strongly to do the same, asking him to help as far as we could. 4 When we promised to see to this, he said that he was very anxious, for he knew that the king, who loves what is good, counts it the greatest thing of all to send for any person who is named, in whatever place, as outstanding above others in conduct and understanding. 5 I have learned that the king rightly says that if he has just and sensible men around him, he will have the greatest protection for his kingdom, since friends will advise him frankly for his benefit; and this is the case with those sent by him. 6 He also gave his oath not to let these men be used up on any other need of his own, but to send them out only for the common improvement of all the citizens. 7 “Living well,” he said, “lies in keeping the commandments of the law,

and this is accomplished by hearing far more than by reading." By putting forward these and similar thoughts he made plain the attitude he had toward them. [8] It is worth mentioning briefly what he showed us in answer to what we asked. I think that many people are curious about certain things in the legislation, about foods and drinks and the animals thought to be unclean. [9] We asked why, when there is a single creation, some animals are held unclean for eating and others even for touching. (The law is scrupulous in most matters, and in these it is extremely so.) He began his answer in this way. [10] "You see," he said, "what effect our habits and our associations have, for when people keep company with the wicked they pick up twisted ways and are wretched through the whole of their lives. But if they live with the wise and sensible, they pass out of ignorance and find the setting right of their lives. [11] So our lawgiver first set out the matters of piety and justice and taught each of them, not only by forbidding but by showing, making plain both the harms and the punishments that God sends on those responsible— [12] for he showed first of all that God is the only God, that his power is made plain through all things, that every place is filled with his dominion, and that nothing done on earth by people in secret escapes him. Whatever anyone does is plain to him, and so are the things that will come about— [13] and by working these points out exactly and setting them in plain view, he showed that if anyone should even think of committing wrong, it would not go unnoticed, still less if he did it, since throughout the whole law he displays the power of God. [14] After this opening, having shown that all other peoples apart from us believe in many gods, though they are in themselves far stronger than the gods they worship for nothing— [15] for they make statues of stone and wood, and they say these are images of people who discovered something useful for living, and they bow down to them, though the lack of feeling in these things lies right at their feet. [16] If anyone were a god on that basis, because of an invention, it would be completely senseless. For these inventors took certain things already in creation, put them together, and showed that they were useful; they did not make the substance of them themselves. So it is empty and foolish to make gods of people like

themselves. [17] Even now there are many people more inventive and
better taught than the people of earlier times, and yet no one would
be in a hurry to worship them. The Greeks who shaped these ideas
and spun these tales believe themselves to be the wisest. [18] Why even
speak of the other worthless worshipers, the Egyptians and those like
them, who have trusted in wild beasts and in nearly every sort of
reptile and animal, and bow down to them and sacrifice to them, both
living and dead? [19] When our lawgiver, a wise man equipped by God
for knowledge of all things, had considered each point, he fenced us
in with unbroken palisades and walls of iron, so that we would not
mix with any of the other nations in any way. We were to stay pure in
body and soul, freed from empty beliefs, worshiping the one mighty
God over the whole of creation. [20] For this reason the leading priests of
Egypt, who have looked deeply into many things and shared in many
affairs, call us "men of God." This title does not belong to the rest,
unless someone worships the God who truly is. The others are men
of food and drink and shelter, [21] for their whole outlook takes refuge
in these things. Among our people these count for nothing, and their
thought is given to the dominion of God throughout the whole of
life. [22] So that we would not be corrupted by mixing with anyone or
by keeping company with the base, he fenced us in on every side
with rules of purity, in accordance with the law, concerning foods
and drinks and touch and hearing and sight. [23] In general, all things
are alike by natural reason, governed by one power, and each one has
a deep meaning in what we avoid using and what we do use. As an
example, I will go over one or two points briefly for you. [24] Do not
fall into the cheap view that Moses[a] made these laws out of fussiness
over mice and weasels and such creatures. No: everything has been
arranged with dignity, for the sake of pure inquiry and the shaping
of character toward justice. [25] Of the birds we eat, all are tame and
distinguished by their cleanness, feeding on wheat and pulses: doves,
turtledoves, francolins, and partridges, and also geese and others of
the kind. [26] As for the birds that are forbidden, you will find them wild
and meat-eating, lording it over the rest by their strength, and feeding
unjustly on the tame birds I have mentioned. Not only this, but they

snatch up lambs and kids, and they harm people, both dead and living. [27] By naming these birds unclean, he set a mark on them. It showed that those for whom the law was laid down must practice justice in their souls and not lord it over anyone, trusting in their own strength, nor take anything away, but steer the affairs of life by what is right, just as the tame birds I mentioned feed on the pulses that grow on the ground and do not use their power to destroy their own kind. [28] Through such examples the lawgiver handed down a sign for those with understanding: to be just, to carry out nothing by force, and not to lord it over others by relying on one's own strength. [29] Since he did not allow us even to touch the creatures I mentioned, because of the character of each, how could one fail to take great care that our own conduct is not bent toward such things? [30] So all the concessions made to us about these birds and about cattle are set out in figurative terms. For having a cloven foot, with the hoof divided into claws, is a sign of separating each action toward what is good. [31] The strength of the whole body, with its working power, rests on the shoulders and legs. So the sign given through these animals compels us to do everything with discrimination, toward justice. It also reminds us that we have been set apart from all other people. [32] Most of the rest of mankind defile themselves by their intercourse, and so commit great injustice, and whole countries and cities are proud of it. They not only take males as partners, but they also defile their own mothers and even daughters. We have been set apart from these things. [33] He has also stamped the mark of remembrance on the very same thing that the mode of separation concerns. For all animals that part the hoof and bring up the cud set forth, clearly for those who understand, the idea of memory. [34] For chewing the cud is nothing other than a recalling of life and existence, since he reckons that life is sustained by food. [35] That is why scripture also urges us, saying: "You shall remember well Yahweh,[b] who has done great and wonderful things in you." For when they are looked into, these things prove great and glorious: first of all, how the body is put together, how food is handled, and the separation of each limb; [36] and much more, the ordering of the senses, the working of the mind and its unseen motion, the quickness to act

in each matter, and the invention of crafts, all of which hold a manner beyond understanding. [37] So he urges us to remember that these things are kept in being by divine power along with their construction. For he has set aside every time and every place for constantly remembering the God who rules and sustains. [38] He commands that over food and drink we first make an offering and only then use them. Through our garments, too, he has given us a mark of remembrance, and in the same way he has ordered us to place the words on our gates and doors, as a reminder of God. [39] On the hands he expressly commands that the sign be fastened, showing plainly that every action must be carried out with justice, remembering our own makeup, and above all the fear of God. [40] He commands also that when we lie down and when we rise we think over the works of God, observing not merely in speech but by reflection the movement and perception that come over us when we go to sleep, and our waking, and how divine and beyond grasp is the change from one to the other. [41] You have now been shown the deeper meaning of the law about separation and remembrance, in our account of the split hoof and the chewing of the cud. These things were not laid down at random or on whatever came into the mind, but for the sake of truth and the marking out of right reasoning. [42] For having given instructions about foods and drinks and everything to do with touch, he commands that we do nothing and hear nothing at random, and that we not use the power of speech to turn toward injustice. [43] The same can be found with the animals. The way of the weasel and of creatures like it, those named in the law, is harmful. [44] Mice damage and harm everything, not only for their own food but so as to make completely useless to a person whatever they happen to set upon harming. [45] The kind of weasel is peculiar. Apart from what was said, it has a damaging nature, for it conceives by way of the ears and gives birth by way of the mouth. [46] For this reason such a way among people is unclean. Those who take in things by hearing and then give them a body in speech, rolling others into evil, accomplish no ordinary wrong, and they are themselves wholly polluted with the stain of impiety. Your king does well to put such people to death, as we understand." [47] I said, "I suppose you mean the

informers; for he keeps bringing on them torture and painful deaths." "Those are the very ones I mean," he said, "for keeping watch to bring about people's ruin is unholy. [48] Our law orders us to do no harm to anyone, whether in word or in deed. So on these matters, too, I have shown you briefly that everything has been regulated toward justice, and that nothing in scripture has been laid down at random or as a fable. Its purpose is that through the whole of life, and in our actions, we practice justice toward all people, remembering the ruling God. [49] So the whole account of foods and of unclean reptiles and animals points toward justice and just dealing among people." [50] It seemed to me that he defended each point well. He also said, about the offerings of calves, rams, and goats, that these must be taken from herds and flocks and be tame animals when sacrificed, and nothing wild, so that those who bring the sacrifices will be aware of nothing proud in themselves, keeping in view the sign given by the one who laid down the rule. For the person who brings the sacrifice makes the offering of his own soul, of his whole manner of life. [51] I think that what was said in that conversation is worth recording on these matters too. So I have gone on to explain to you, Philocrates, the dignity and natural reasoning of the law, because of your love of learning.

Notes

- a (6:24) Greek *Mouses*, from Hebrew *Mosheh*, "drawn out" (Exodus 2:10).
- b (6:35) The Greek has *Kyrios*, "Lord," the word the Greek Bible uses in place of the Hebrew name Yahweh. The words echo Deuteronomy 7:18 and 10:21.

Chapter 7

[1] Eleazar offered a sacrifice, chose the men, prepared many gifts for the king, and dispatched us with a heavy escort. [2] When we reached Alexandria, the king was told of our arrival. Andreas and I were admitted to the court, and we greeted the king warmly and handed over the letters from Eleazar. [3] He placed great value on meeting the men who had been sent, and ordered every other official dismissed and the men summoned. [4] This struck everyone as remarkable, since the custom was that people who came on business could reach the king's presence only on the fifth day, and envoys from kings or from

important cities were barely admitted to the court within thirty. But he thought those who had come worthy of greater honor, and he judged the standing of the one who had sent them. So he dismissed those he thought unnecessary and waited, walking about, until he could greet them as they came in. [5] They came forward with the gifts that had been sent and the precious skins on which the law was written in gold letters in Hebrew script. The parchment was wonderfully worked, and the joins between the sheets had been made so that they could not be felt. When the king caught sight of the men, he inquired about the books. [6] They uncovered the wrappings and unrolled the sheets. The king stood there a long time, bowed down about seven times, and said, "I thank you, men, and the one who sent you even more, and above all God, whose words these are." [7] Everyone who had come, and everyone who was present, cried out together with one voice, "Well said, O king!" Tears came to him, and he was full of joy. For the strain on the soul and the weight of such an honor force tears at moments of success. [8] He ordered the rolls to be put back in order. Then he greeted the men and said, "It was right, you godly men, that I first pay reverence to the books for whose sake I sent for you, and only after that hold out my right hand to you. That is why I did this first. [9] I count this day, on which you arrived, a great day, and it will be marked every year all the days of our life. It also happens to coincide with news of our victory in the sea battle against Antigonus.[a] So today I will want to dine with you. [10] Everything will be provided for you in a fitting way," he said, "for you to use, and for me with you." They were delighted. He ordered that the best lodgings near the citadel be given them and that the banquet be prepared. [11] Nicanor,[b] the chief usher, called in Dorotheus,[c] who had been put in charge of these matters, and ordered him to carry out the preparations for each person. For this was how the kings had arranged it, as you can still see today: for every city that has its own customs in drink, food, and bedding, there was an officer in charge. Preparations were made according to those customs whenever the envoys came before the kings, so that, troubled in nothing, they could pass the time cheerfully. That was done for these men too. [12] Dorotheus was a very careful

man and had charge of such matters. He laid out everything that was handled through him, divided up for such receptions. He made the arrangement of the couches in two groups, as the king had ordered: half of the guests were to recline at his right hand, and the rest after his own couch, leaving nothing lacking in honoring the men. 13 When they were seated, the king told Dorotheus to proceed according to the customs followed by all who come to him from Judea. For that reason he excused the sacred heralds, the sacrificers, and the others who were accustomed to make the prayers, and he asked Elisha,[d] who had come with us and was an elder among the priests, to make the prayer. Elisha stood and spoke in a worthy way. 14 "O king, may God Almighty fill you with all the good things he has created. May he grant that you keep these, with your wife and children and those who share your mind, never failing, all the days of your life." 15 When he had said this, applause burst out with shouting and glad joy for a long time. Then they turned to enjoy what had been prepared, with all the services carried out under Dorotheus's direction. Among those serving were royal pages and some of those honored by the king.

Notes

- a (7:9) Greek *Antigonos*, perhaps "worthy of his fathers." The sea battle is not identified with certainty.
- b (7:11) Greek *Nikanor*, "victorious."
- c (7:11) Greek *Dorotheos*, "gift of God."
- d (7:13) Hebrew *Elisha*, "God saves." He is the Elisha of the first tribe named in 4:4.

Chapter 8

1 When he found an opening after an interval, he asked the man on the first couch (for they were seated by age), "How could I keep my kingdom free of stumbling to the end?" 2 After a brief pause he said, "You would govern best by imitating God's constant gentleness. If you practice patience and treat those who deserve it more mildly, as each deserves, you will turn them from wickedness and bring them to repentance." 3 The king praised him and asked the next, "How could I do everything well?" He answered, "If you keep justice toward everyone, you will do each thing well for yourself, understanding that every thought is clear to God. If you begin from the fear of God, you

will fail in nothing." [4] The king gladly accepted this answer and asked another, "How could I have friends who are like myself?" He said, "If they see you taking great care of the crowds you rule. You will do this by observing the good God does for the human race, supplying health and food and everything else in due season." [5] The king confirmed this and asked the next, "How could I win good reports in my business and judgments, even from those who lose their case?" He said, "If you are the same to all in what you say, and do nothing proudly or by the force of your own strength against those who do wrong. [6] You will do this by looking at the order God has set. Requests are granted to those who are worthy, and those who fail are shown, through dreams or events, the harm that is theirs. God does not strike them according to their sins or the greatness of his strength; he acts with gentleness." [7] He praised this man well too and asked the next in order, "How could I be undefeated in the demands of war?" He said, "If you do not put your trust in crowds or forces, but call on God in everything, so that he may direct your undertakings as you carry out everything justly." [8] He welcomed this man too and asked another, "How could I be feared by my enemies?" He said, "If, though you have a great supply of arms and forces, you know that these are empty and over a long time accomplish little in the end. For God, who grants respites and shows the fear of his dominion, builds it into every mind." [9] He praised this man as well and said to the next, "What would be the finest thing for me in life?" He said, "To know that God is ruler of all, and that even in our finest actions it is not we who direct what we have planned. God brings everyone's plans to completion and guides them with his power." [10] He said this man too spoke well, and asked another, "How could I keep everything unharmed and hand down the same disposition to my descendants to the end?" He said, "By praying always to God to receive good thoughts for what is to be done, and by urging your descendants not to be dazzled by fame or riches. For these are granted by God, and they do not hold their supremacy over everything by their own doing." [11] He confirmed this and asked the one after him, "How could I bear what happens with moderation?" He said, "If you accept in advance that God made all people to share

in the greatest evils as well as in goods, and that no human being can be free from a mixture of them. God gives courage, and he must be asked for it." 12 He welcomed this man too, and said that everyone was answering well. "I will ask one more and then stop for now, so that we may turn to pleasure and pass the time agreeably. In the next six days, one after another, I will learn something more from the rest." 13 Then he asked the man, "What does courage aim at?" He said, "That what has been rightly planned be carried out as intended in the actions of danger. And God brings everything to completion for you, O king, since you plan well and to good purpose." 14 Everyone cheered and signaled their approval with applause. The king said to the philosophers (not a few were present with them), "These men, I think, stand out in virtue and have greater understanding, since, though given such questions on the spur of the moment, they answered as they should, all of them making God the starting point of their discourse." 15 Menedemus[a] of Eretria,[b] a philosopher, said, "Yes, O king. All things are governed by providence, and they have rightly assumed that man is God's creation, so it follows that all power and all beauty of speech begin with God." 16 The king nodded, the discussion of these matters ended, and they turned to merriment. When evening came, the banquet broke up. 17 On the next day the reclining and the drinking went on in the same arrangement. When the king thought it a good time to ask the men something, he questioned those who came next after the ones who had answered the day before. 18 He began the conversation with the eleventh, for ten had been questioned the day before. When there was silence, he asked, "How could one stay rich?" 19 After a short pause, the one who received the question said, "If he does nothing unworthy of himself or dissolute, if he does not spend on empty and vain things, and if he wins those under him to goodwill by kindness. For God is the cause of good things for all, and one must follow him." 20 The king praised this man and asked another, "How could one keep to the truth?" He answered, "By knowing that a lie brings great shame on everyone, and much more on kings. Since they have authority to do what they want, why would they lie? You must also take this in, O king: God loves truth." 21 He welcomed this man

too, looked at the next, and said, “What does the teaching of wisdom consist of?” The other declared, “As you do not want evils to come to yourself but want a share in all good things, so you ought to deal with your subjects and with those who do wrong, and admonish the good and noble among people rather gently. For God leads all people with gentleness.” [22] He praised him and said to the next, “How could one be kind to people?” He said, “By observing that the human race grows and is born over a long time and with the greatest suffering. So one should not punish readily or heap abuse on people, knowing that human life is made of pains and penalties. If you think over each case, you will turn toward mercy, for God is merciful.” [23] He welcomed this man and put to the next man this question: “What does a kingdom need most?” “To keep oneself free of bribes,” he said, “to be sober for most of one’s life, to put justice first, and to make friends of such people. For God loves justice.” [24] He took note of this and turned to another: “What does piety consist of?” He said, “To understand that God is at work and aware of everything at every moment, and that no one who commits an injustice or an evil could escape him. As God benefits the whole world, so you also, if you imitate him, would be free from stumbling.” [25] He applauded this and said to another, “What is the limit of ruling?” He said, “To rule oneself well, and, not being carried away by wealth and glory, to desire nothing proud or unseemly, if you reason well. For everything is at your command as if it were nothing. God needs nothing and is gentle. You too, so far as you are human, should keep this in mind, and not reach for many things, but for what suffices for ruling.” [26] He praised him and asked another, “How could one best deliberate?” He answered, “If he constantly puts justice before everything and considers injustice a loss of life. For God always foretells the greatest good for the just.” [27] He praised this man and said to the next, “How could one be untroubled in sleep?” He said, “You have asked a thing that is hard to explain. We cannot keep ourselves in hand in what happens in sleep, but are held by a perception that does not reason. [28] In the soul we are affected by what comes upon us as if we were really seeing it. We lose our reason, in that we suppose we are out on the open sea in ships, or

flying through the air and carried off to other places, and other things of the kind, and the one who supposes these things does not stand firm.[c] 29 Still, as far as I can reach it, I have understood it this way. In every way, O king, bring both what is said and what is done back to piety, so that you are conscious that, keeping to virtue, you choose neither to show favor against reason nor, using your authority, to set aside what is just. 30 In most cases, the matters in which each person passes the time while awake are the same ones in which the mind dwells during sleep. And a person who directs all reasoning and action toward what is finest does so awake and asleep. For that reason steadiness is always with you." 31 He praised this man warmly and said to the other, "Since you are the tenth to give an answer, once you have spoken we will turn to the dinner." 32 He asked, "How could we do nothing unworthy of ourselves?" He said, "Keep your eye always on your own reputation and eminence, so that you speak and think in keeping with them, knowing that all those you rule think and talk about you. 33 For you must not appear the least of the actors. The role they must play, they watch carefully and do everything to match it. But you are not playing a part; you truly reign, since God has given you rule that suits your character." 34 The king applauded him warmly and with great friendliness for a long time, and then the men were urged to go and sleep. When this was finished, they went on to the next day's banquet. 35 On the following day the same arrangement was followed, and when the king thought it a good time to ask the men something, he asked the first of those who remained for the next question: "What is the strongest rule?" 36 He said, "To rule oneself and not be swept along by one's impulses. For in every person the mind naturally leans toward something. 37 Most people are likely to be inclined toward food, drink, and pleasures; kings, toward the conquest of territory, in keeping with the greatness of their glory. But moderation in everything is good. Take what God gives and hold on to it; do not desire what is out of reach."

Notes

- a (8:15) Greek *Menedemos*, "staying with the people."
- b (8:15) Greek *Eretria*, a city on the island of Euboea, perhaps "city of rowers."

- c (8:28) The Greek of this verse is damaged, and the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 9

1 Pleased with what had been said, he asked the next, “How could one be free of envy?” After a pause he said, “First, if he understood that God apportions glory and great wealth to kings, and that no one is king by his own doing. All people want a share in this glory, but they cannot have it, for it is God’s gift.” 2 He praised the man at some length and asked another, “How could one look down on his enemies?” He said, “If you have practiced goodwill toward all people and built up friendships, you would take no one into account. To be well liked by all and to have received this fine gift from God is the strongest protection.” 3 He agreed with this and told the next to answer, asking, “How could one keep a good reputation?” He said, “By being generous and open-handed to others, with eagerness and kindness, you would never lose your reputation. And so that what I have said may last for you, call on God always.” 4 He praised him and asked another, “How should one show a love of honor?” He said, “Everyone thinks one should show it to those who are friendly to us. I suppose we should show a gracious generosity above all toward those who think differently, so that we may thereby lead them to what is fitting and to their own advantage. One must pray to God that this be accomplished, for he controls the minds of all.” 5 He agreed with this and told the sixth to give his view, asking, “Whom should one show favor to?” He answered, “To parents always, for God has made the greatest commandment about honoring parents. Next he approves devotion to friends, calling a friend equal to one’s own soul. You do well to bring all people into friendship with you.” 6 He encouraged this man and asked the next after him, “What is worthy of being called beauty?” He said, “Piety. For this is a kind of beauty that takes first place, and its power is love, which is God’s gift. You too possess it, with all good things contained in it.” 7 He applauded most warmly and said to another, “How could one who has stumbled win back the same reputation?” He said, “It is not possible for you to stumble, since you have sown kindnesses among all people, and

these sprout goodwill, which is stronger than the greatest weapons and carries the greatest security. [8] If some do stumble, they must no longer do the things at which they stumble, but win friendship and act justly. To be a doer of good, and not of the opposite, is God's gift." [9] He was pleased with this and said to the next, "How could one be free of grief?" He said, "If he harms no one but helps everyone, following justice. For its fruits produce freedom from grief. [10] One must also beg God to keep from harming us what comes up against our own choice. I mean such things as death, sickness, griefs, and the like. As for you, since you are pious, none of these will come near you." [11] He praised this man too, and asked the tenth, "What is greatest in glory?" He said, "Honoring God. This is done by neither gifts nor sacrifices, but by a pure soul and a holy understanding, that all things are made and governed by God according to his will. You have always held this view, and it can be seen by everyone from what you have accomplished and are accomplishing." [12] Raising his voice, the king welcomed them all and urged them on, and those present joined in the cheers, especially the philosophers. For the visitors were far ahead of them in conduct and speech, since they made God their starting point. After that the king went on to show his friendliness by proposing toasts. [13] On the next day the banquet followed the same arrangement. When the moment suited the king, he put his questions to those who followed the men already answered. He said to the first, "Can understanding be taught?" He said, "It is the makeup of the soul, through divine power, to take in everything fine and to turn away from the opposite." [14] He agreed and asked the next, "What contributes most to health?" He said, "Self-control. It cannot be gained unless God shapes the mind toward it." [15] He encouraged this man and said to another, "How could one repay parents with the thanks they deserve?" He said, "By causing them no grief. That cannot be unless God leads the mind to the finest things." [16] He nodded to this and asked the next, "How could one be a good listener?" He said, "By understanding that it is useful to know everything, so that when events come, one may choose something of what he has heard and set it against the circumstances of the moment, with God's hand to

guide him. That is to say, the accomplishment of one's actions comes from God." [17] He praised this man and said to another, "How could one do nothing against the law?" He said, "By knowing that God gave the ideas to the lawmakers to preserve the lives of people, you would follow them." [18] He welcomed this man and said to another, "What is the benefit of kinship?" He declared, "If, when misfortune comes on our relatives, we count ourselves diminished and suffer as if it were ourselves, then the strength of kinship appears.[a] [19] When this is done, glory and progress will be found among such people. For help given with goodwill, as if from oneself, cannot be dissolved by anything, and in good times there is no need of anything from them. But one must pray to God, who makes everything good." [20] In the same way he welcomed this man and asked another, "How does fearlessness come about?" He said, "When the mind is aware that it has done nothing wrong, and God directs it to deliberate well in everything." [21] He applauded this and said to another, "How could one keep right reason ready at hand?" He said, "If he always keeps in view the misfortunes of people, knowing that God takes away prosperity and raises up others to be honored." [22] He welcomed this man too, and asked the next to answer, "How could one avoid turning to ease and pleasures?" He said, "By keeping in mind that he rules a great kingdom and leads many crowds, and that his thoughts should be on nothing else but the care of them. And by asking God that none of his duties be neglected." [23] He praised this man, the tenth, and asked, "How could one recognize those who act toward him with some deceit?" He declared, "By watching whether their conduct is free and whether good order holds in their greetings, in their counsel, and in the rest of their dealings with those around him, and whether they overdo nothing beyond what is right in friendliness and in the rest of their behavior. [24] God will lead your mind to the finest things, O king." The king applauded them all and praised each by name, and those present did the same. Then they turned to song. [25] On the next day, finding the occasion, he put a question to the next, "What is the greatest neglect?" He said, "If someone is careless about his children and does not strive to bring them up in every way. We always pray to God,

less for ourselves than for our descendants, that every good thing may be theirs. That children come to share in self-control happens by God's power." [26] He said this man spoke well and asked another, "How could one be a lover of his country?" He said, "By setting it before himself that it is good to live, and also to die, in one's own country. Living abroad brings contempt on the poor and shame on the rich, as if they had been driven out for wickedness. By doing good to all, as you constantly do, since God gives you favor with all, you will appear a lover of your country." [27] He listened to him and asked the following man, "How should one get along with a wife?" He said, "By knowing that the female sex is bold, and energetic in whatever it wants, and easily turned by faulty reasoning, and by nature made weak. One must treat her sensibly and not oppose her in quarrels. [28] For life is steered rightly when the one at the helm knows to what goal the course must be made. And by calling on God, life is steered rightly in everything." [29] He agreed with this man and asked the next, "How could one be without fault?" He said, "By doing everything with careful thought and not believing slanders, but being yourself the tester of what is said, directing the matters brought before you by judgment, and carrying them out by judgment. In that way you would be without fault, O king. To devise such things and to live by them is the work of divine power." [30] He was delighted by what was said and asked another, "How could one be free of anger?" He said, "By knowing that he has authority over all, and that if he gave way to anger he would bring death, which is useless and painful if the life of many is taken away because he is lord. When all are subject and no one is opposing, why would he be angry? [31] One must know that God governs the whole world with kindness and without any anger. You must follow him, O king." [32] He said this man had answered well and asked the one after, "What is good counsel?" He declared, "To do everything well with careful thought, setting out in the planning the harmful things on the opposite side of the argument, so that when we have thought through each one, we may be well advised and what was proposed may be carried out. And best of all, by God's power every plan will reach its completion for you as you practice

piety." [33] He said this man too had done well and asked another, "What is philosophy?" He declared, "To reason well about each thing that happens and not be carried away by impulses, but to study the harms that come out of desires, and to do what suits the moment in a properly measured way. To gain a firm grasp of these things, we must serve God." [34] He marked this answer and asked another, "How could one win acceptance as a stranger in a foreign land?" He said, "By being equal to everyone, and appearing to be lesser rather than greater than those among whom he is a stranger. For in general God welcomes what is humble according to nature, and the human race is kind to those who submit." [35] He affirmed these answers and asked another, "How could what one builds last afterward?" He said, "If he makes great and dignified works, so that those who see them spare them for their beauty; if he sends away none of those who work on them; and if he does not force others to do the needed work without pay. [36] By thinking that God cares for the human race, providing them with health and keen senses and the rest, he will himself do something fitting, paying back the reward for their labors. What is done in justice is also what lasts." [37] Saying that this man also spoke well, he questioned the tenth: "What does wisdom yield?" He said, "Not to be aware of having done any wrong, and to pass one's life in truth. [38] From these, the greatest joy and steadiness of soul come to you, O greatest of kings, and good hopes in God, as you hold your rule with piety." When all heard this, they cheered with louder applause. After this the king, filled with joy, turned to the toasts. [39] On the next day the arrangements for the drinking went as before, and when the moment came, the king put questions to those who were left. To the first he said, "How could one avoid turning to pride?" [40] He answered, "If he keeps equality and reminds himself in each case that, though a man, he rules over men. God brings down the proud and lifts up the gentle and humble." [41] He encouraged him and put a question to the next: "Which counselors should one use?" "Those who have been tested through many affairs," he said, "and who keep their goodwill toward him unspoiled, and all who share his ways. God shows himself to the worthy in such matters." [42] He praised him

and turned to another: “What must a king possess above all?” “The kindness and love of those under him,” he answered. “For through these an unbreakable bond of goodwill comes about. That these arise by choice, God brings about.” 43 He praised him highly and questioned another, “What is the goal of speech?” He said, “To persuade the one who disagrees, by showing the harms through an ordered series of points. In this way you will win the listener not by opposing him but by using praise to persuade. Persuasion is directed by God’s working.” 44 He said this man spoke well and asked another, “How could one get along with the crowds of every kind in the kingdom?” “By playing the fitting part with each,” he said, “taking justice as your guide, as you do, since God gives you the ability to reason well.” 45 He was pleased with this and said to another, “What should one grieve over?” He answered, “What happens to friends, when we see it become long-lasting and inescapable. When they have died and are released from evils, reason does not call for grief. But people refer things back to themselves and to what concerns them, and so all people grieve. To escape every evil comes by God’s power.” 46 He said that this man had answered as he should, and said to another, “How does dishonor come about?” He said, “When pride leads, and boldness that never stops, contempt grows up with them, and the loss of glory. God is lord of all glory, and tips it where he wishes.” 47 He confirmed this answer too and asked the next, “Whom should one trust?” “Those who are with you out of goodwill,” he said, “and not out of fear or for the sake of attention, bringing everything round to profit. The one is a sign of love; the other, of ill will and opportunism, for whoever is driven by greed is born a traitor. You have well-wishers all around you, since God gives you good counsel.”

Notes

- a (9:18) The Greek of verses 18 and 19 is difficult, and the sense is uncertain.

Chapter 10

1 He encouraged this man and asked another, “What preserves favor and honor?” He said, “Virtue. For it is the accomplishment of fine works and drives off evil. You keep up your nobility toward everyone,

having it as a gift from God." [2] He received this man warmly too and asked the eleventh (for there were two more than seventy),[a] "How could one be at peace in spirit even in wars?" He declared, "By understanding that he has done no wrong to anyone under him, and that all will struggle on behalf of his benefactions, knowing that even if they depart from life, you are the caretaker of their lives. [3] For you never cease setting everyone right, since God has given you good sense." The king marked their approval with applause and welcomed them all warmly. Toasting each one at greater length, he turned to enjoyment, keeping company with the men in cheer and great joy. [4] On the seventh of the days, with greater preparation made and many more arriving from the cities (for there were a good number of envoys), the king, when the occasion came, asked the leader of those who remained to be questioned, "How could one avoid being led astray by false reasoning?" [5] He said, "By testing the speaker, and what is said, and what it is about, and by asking the same things over a longer time in different ways. A keen mind, able to judge each matter, is a fine gift of God, and you have it, O king." [6] The king marked his approval with applause and asked another, "Why do most people not accept virtue?" "Because all people are by nature lacking in self-control and have turned toward pleasures," he said. "From this injustice grows, and the flood of greed. [7] The state of virtue holds back those who are carried toward indulgence, and orders them to put self-control and justice first. And God leads in all of these." [8] The king said this man had answered well and asked, "What should kings follow?" He said, "The laws, so that through just actions they may rebuild people's lives. By doing this you have laid down a memorial of yourself that will never fade, following a divine command." [9] Saying this man had also spoken well, he asked the next, "Who should be made a general?" He said, "Those who hate evil, who imitate your conduct so as always to be well thought of, and who do what is just. This is what you do, greatest of kings, since God has given you a crown of justice." [10] He welcomed him aloud, looked at the next, and said, "Whom should one set over the armies as commanders?" He declared, "Those who excel in courage and justice, who think much

more of saving their men than of winning, and who risk their own lives in daring. As God does good to all, you too, imitating him, do good to those under you." [11] The king said this man had answered well and asked another, "What kind of person is worth admiring?" He said, "One who is supplied with glory, wealth, and power and yet is equal to all in spirit. You are admirable in doing this, since God gives you the care for such things." [12] He applauded this man too and said to another, "What should kings occupy themselves with for most of their time?" He said, "With reading, and with studying the reports of missions and journeys, whatever has been written about kingdoms to set people right and keep them safe. In doing this you have gained a glory that others cannot reach, since God brings your wishes to completion." [13] He addressed this man too with energy and asked another, "What pastimes should one choose in times of relaxation and ease?" He said, "To watch whatever is played out with restraint, and to set before one's eyes the things of life that are done with propriety and decorum. For even in these there is some benefit. [14] Often even from the smallest things something worth choosing is shown. You, having practiced every kind of restraint, philosophize through your actions out of nobility, and are honored by God." [15] He was pleased with what had been said and asked the ninth, "How should one spend banquets?" He said, "By inviting those who love learning and are able to remind one of what benefits the kingdom and the lives of those who are ruled. You would find nothing more harmonious or more musical than these. [16] For such people are dear to God, having trained their minds toward the finest things. You do this too, since everything is directed for you by God." [17] He was delighted with this and asked the next, "Which is better for the crowds: to have as king over them one who was a private citizen, or one born of a king?" He said, "The one who is best by nature. [18] For kings born of kings become savage and harsh toward their subjects. And even more, some private citizens who have known evils and shared in poverty have, once they ruled crowds, turned out harsher than godless tyrants. [19] But as I said, a good character that has had a share in education is able to rule. So you are a great king, not so much for the glory of your

rule and wealth as for the fact that in gentleness and kindness you surpass all people, since God has given you these." [20] He praised this man too for a long time and asked the last of all, "What is greatest in a kingdom?" He said, "That those under him always live in peace, and that justice is quickly obtained in the courts. [21] These come about through the leader, when he hates evil and loves good and values highly the saving of a human life. You too have regarded injustice as the greatest evil, and by governing everything justly you have built up a reputation that will not fade, since God has given you a mind that is pure and unmixed with any evil." [22] When he had finished, applause burst out with shouting and joy for a long while. When it stopped, the king took a cup and drank a toast to all who were present and to the words that had been spoken. Before them all he said, "The greatest good has come to me through your coming. [23] I have been helped in many ways, since you have laid down teaching for me on how to rule." He ordered three talents of silver[b] to be given to each one, and an attendant to take him back to his quarters. When all cheered, the banquet was filled with joy, and the king, without pause, turned to cheerfulness.

Notes

- a (10:2) The seventy-two translators had been questioned ten at a time on seven days. That leaves two more for the last day.
- b (10:23) About 225 pounds (102 kilograms) of silver for each man. The Greek says three *talents*, at about 75 pounds each.

Chapter 11

[1] Forgive me, Philocrates, if I have said too much on these matters. I admired the men beyond what was needed, since they gave on the spot answers that would have needed a great deal of time. [2] The questioner had thought through each point, and the answerers matched their replies to his questions. To me they seemed deserving of wonder, and so to those present, above all the philosophers. I think the record will seem unbelievable to all who take it up. [3] To lie about what is recorded is not fitting, and if I strayed at all, it would be unholy in matters like these. What happened is what we set out, keeping clear of every error. That is why, after I had accepted the

force of their speech, I tried to get from the recorders each of the things that were done in the king's audiences and at the banquets. 4 For it is the custom, as you also know, that from the day the king starts his business until he lies down to sleep, everything said and done is written down, and this is a good and useful practice. 5 On the next day, what was done and said the day before is read aloud before the business begins, and if anything was done improperly, the act is corrected. 6 So I got everything accurately from the records, as I have said, and have set it down, knowing your love of learning for what is useful. 7 After three days Demetrius took them, crossed the sea-wall of seven stadia[a] that runs out to the island,[b] crossed the bridge, and went on toward the northern part. He held a meeting in a house prepared by the shore, splendid and set in great stillness, and urged the men to complete the translation, with everything needed provided. 8 They carried out each part, making their versions agree with one another by comparing them. What came out of the agreement was properly written down by Demetrius. 9 The sessions went on until the ninth hour,[c] and after that the men were released to care for their bodies, with everything they chose provided in abundance. 10 Besides this, Dorotheus also provided every day everything that was prepared for the king, since he had been ordered to by the king. At dawn each day they came to the court, and after greeting the king they went back to their own place. 11 As is the custom of all the Jews, they washed their hands in the sea so that they could pray to God, and then turned to reading and explaining each passage. 12 I asked this too: "Why do they pray after washing their hands?" They explained that it is a witness that they have done no evil, since every action is carried out through the hands. They were transferring everything, nobly and piously, to justice and truth. 13 As we said before, they gathered each day at that place, which was pleasant for its quiet and brightness, and completed the task set. And so it happened that the translation was finished in seventy-two days, as though it had been planned that way. 14 When it was completed, Demetrius gathered the Jewish community at the place where the translation had been finished and read it to everyone, with the translators present. They also received great approval from

the crowd, as men who had brought about great good. 15 In the same way they welcomed Demetrius and urged him to give the whole law, now translated, to their leaders. 16 When the scrolls had been read, the priests, the elders of the translators, those from the community, and the leaders of the crowd stood and said, "Since it has been translated well and piously and with precision in every respect, it is right that it remain as it is and that no alteration be made." 17 All agreed. As is their custom, they ordered a curse on anyone who altered it by adding anything, changing any part of what was written, or removing anything. They did this rightly, so that it would always be kept lasting and unchanged. 18 When this was reported to the king, he rejoiced greatly, for the purpose he had held seemed to have been safely accomplished. All of it was read to him, and he was amazed at the thought of the lawgiver. He asked Demetrius, "Why is it that, though such great matters were accomplished, none of the historians or poets set out to mention them?" 19 Demetrius said, "Because the legislation is sacred and came through God. Some who tried were struck by God and gave up the attempt. 20 I heard from Theopompus[d] that when he was about to include in his history some of the things already translated from the law, rather rashly, his mind was disturbed for more than thirty days. In a lull he pleaded with God, and it became clear to him why this was happening. 21 It was shown to him in a dream that he wanted to pry into divine matters and carry them out to common people. After he held back, he recovered. 22 I also learned from Theodectes,[e] the tragic poet, that when he was about to bring something recorded in the book into a play, his eyes went blind with cataract. He suspected that this had happened to him for that reason, appeased God, and after many days recovered." 23 When the king, as I said, had learned these things from Demetrius, he bowed in reverence and gave orders that the books be guarded with great care and kept pure. 24 He urged the translators to come to him more often if they returned to Judea. It was right, he said, that he send them off, and when they came, as was proper, they would have him as a friend and would receive the greatest attention from him. 25 He ordered their departure to be prepared, and showed the men great generosity. He

gave each of them three of the finest robes, two talents of gold,[f] a cup worth a talent,[g] and a complete set of furnishings for a dining room with three couches. 26 He also sent to Eleazar, along with their escort, ten couches with silver feet and all their equipment, a cup worth thirty talents,[h] ten robes, purple cloth, a splendid crown, a hundred bolts of fine linen, and bowls, dishes, and two golden mixing bowls for dedication. 27 He wrote also to urge that if any of the men chose to come back to him, Eleazar should not stop them. He valued the company of educated men and wished to spend his wealth lavishly on such people and not on vain things. 28 You, Philocrates, as I promised, now have the account. I think it will please you more than the books of the myth-tellers, for you lean toward the study of things that can benefit the mind, and spend most of your time on them. I will try to write down the rest of what is noteworthy as well, so that as you go through it you may carry off the finest prize of your wish.

Notes

- a (11:7) About 4,200 feet (1.3 kilometers). The Greek says seven *stadia*, at about 600 feet each.
- b (11:7) The island of Pharos, whose name means “lighthouse,” though this verse does not name it.
- c (11:9) About 3 p.m. The Greek counts daytime hours from about 6 a.m.
- d (11:20) Greek *Theopompos*, “sent by God.” Theopompus of Chios was a Greek historian of the fourth century BC.
- e (11:22) Greek *Theodektes*, “received by God.” Theodectes of Phaselis was a tragic poet of the fourth century BC.
- f (11:25) About 150 pounds (68 kilograms) of gold. The Greek says two *talents*, at about 75 pounds each.
- g (11:25) About 75 pounds (34 kilograms).
- h (11:26) About 2,250 pounds (1,020 kilograms).